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远瞳 著
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Deep Sea Embers

Yuan Tong

Translated by bcat00

Mystery | Cosmic Horror | Psychological | Xianxia

SYNOPSIS

On that day, the fog blocked everything.

On that day, he became the captain of a ghost ship.

On that day, he stepped through the thick fog and confronted a completely subverted and fragmented world.

The old order had vanished, strange phenomena dominated the endless seas beyond civilized society, and isolated island city-states and fleets of ships challenged the sea that had become the last ember of lights for the civilized world. All of this while the shadows of the

old days were still stirring in the deep sea, waiting to devour this world that was about to die.

But for the new captain of the ghost ship, there was only one question he had to consider first — Who knows how to steer this ship?!

Chapter 1: That Day, the Fog Was Thick

Endless thick fog rolled outside the window. It was so dense that it felt as if the whole world had vanished beyond it. Only a dim, muddled daylight pushed through the fog into the room, leaving this quiet place in a half-dark, half-bright gloom.

Inside the slightly messy studio apartment, Zhou Ming sat hunched over his desk. The clutter on the table had been roughly pushed aside, and his haggard face hovered over a notebook as he wrote quickly:

“Seventh day. Nothing has changed. The thick fog still covers everything outside the window. The window is sealed by some unknown force… The whole room feels as if something has ‘cast’ it into some kind of anomalous space…

“There is no way to contact the outside world. There is no water or power. But the lamp stays on, and the computer can still start up—even though I have already pulled out its power cord…”

A faint sound of wind seemed to blow from the direction of the window. Zhou Ming, who was bent over his diary, suddenly lifted his head. A small light came into his tired eyes. But a second later he saw it was only his imagination. Outside that window there was still only the pale, clinging fog. A dead, silent world lay there, coldly covering his tiny home.

His gaze swept across the windowsill. He saw the wrench and hammer tossed there at random. They were the traces of how he had tried to leave

the room in the past few days. Now those hard, clumsy tools just lay there in silence, as if mocking his helpless state.

After a few seconds, Zhou Ming's face became calm again. With this calm that felt like an anomaly, he lowered his head once more and went back to his writing:

"I am trapped, with no idea how to get out. In the past few days, I even tried to tear up the roof, the walls, and the floor. But even when I used all my strength, I could not leave the slightest mark on the walls. This room has become like… like a box that has been 'cast' together with space itself, with no way out at all…

"Except for that door.

"But what is beyond that door… is even more wrong."

Zhou Ming stopped again. He slowly read over the words he had just written. Then he flipped through the diary a bit carelessly, looking at what he had recorded in the last few days—heavy, gloomy lines, meaningless wild thoughts, impatient doodles, and bad jokes he wrote when he forced himself to relax.

He did not know what use any of this writing had, or who might ever read this nonsense in the future. In fact, he was not even someone who usually kept a diary. As a middle-school teacher whose free time was very limited, he had never had much energy to spend on something like this.

But now, whether he liked it or not, he had plenty of spare time.

After one sleep, he had found himself trapped in his own room.

Outside the window was thick fog that would not fade. The fog was so dense that he could not see anything but fog itself. It was as if the whole world had lost the cycle of day and night. The same dull and sleepy light filled the room all twenty-four hours. The window was locked. Water and

power were cut off. His phone had no signal. No matter how much noise he made in the room, he could not draw any help from the outside.

It was like an absurd nightmare, a dream where everything moved against the laws of nature. But Zhou Ming had already used every method he could think of to make sure of one thing: there were no illusions here, and no dream. There was only a world that was no longer normal, and a self that still seemed more or less normal for now.

He took a deep breath. His gaze finally rested on the only door at the far end of the room.

It was just an ordinary, cheap white wooden door. The calendar he had forgotten to take down last year was still pinned to it. The handle had been worn bright from use. The doormat in front of it sat a little crooked.

That door could open.

If this sealed, twisted room was a cage, then the cruelest thing about the cage was that it kept a door that could be pushed open at any time. It tempted the prisoner inside, again and again, to push it and leave. But beyond that door was not the “outside” Zhou Ming wanted.

Out there were no old yet familiar stairwell halls, no bright sunlit streets filled with lively people, none of the things he knew.

There was only a strange, unsettling foreign place. And “over there” was also a trap he could not escape.

But Zhou Ming knew he did not have much time left to hesitate. The so-called “choice” had never really existed from the very beginning.

His food stores were limited. Only the last quarter remained of his few large containers of mineral water. He had already tried every method of escape and every way of calling for help inside this sealed room. Now there was

only one road left to him: he had to get ready and go to the other side of the door to seek a single slim chance to live.

Maybe he would even get a chance to find out what had caused this bizarre and desperate supernatural situation.

Zhou Ming took a light breath, lowered his head, and wrote the last few paragraphs in the diary:

"…But no matter what, the only choice left now is to go to the other side of the door. At least on that strange ship I can still find some food. And the exploration and preparations I did over there in the past few days should be enough to let me survive on that ship… even though the preparations I could make there were actually very limited.

"Last of all, to those who come after. If I do not come back, and one day in the future some kind of rescue worker opens this room and sees this diary, please do not treat what I have written as an absurd story—it really happened. As chilling as it is, there really was a person named Zhou Ming, trapped inside this mad and eerie space-time phenomenon.

"I have done everything I can in this diary to describe all the Anomaly phenomena I saw, and to record every effort I made to escape. If there really are any 'later ones', please at least remember my name. At least remember that all this once happened."

Zhou Ming closed the diary, tossed the pen into the holder beside him, and slowly stood up from behind the desk.

It was time to leave, before he sank completely into helplessness and a dead end.

But after a short moment of thought, he did not walk straight to the only door that might lead to the "outside". Instead, he went directly to his bed.

He had to face the “foreign land” beyond the door in the best state he could manage. Right now, he was not ready, especially in his mind.

Zhou Ming did not know if he would be able to fall asleep. But even forcing himself to lie on the bed and empty his mind was better than going “over there” while he was too mentally tired.

Eight hours later, Zhou Ming opened his eyes.

Outside the window there was still a chaos of fog. The light that knew neither day nor night carried a heavy gloom that pressed on him.

Zhou Ming ignored what lay beyond the window. He took some food from his dwindling stores and ate until he was almost full. Then he walked to the full-length mirror in the corner of the room.

The man in the mirror still had messy hair and looked quite worn out. There was nothing special about his looks or presence. But Zhou Ming kept staring stubbornly at himself in the mirror, as if trying to burn this image into his mind forever.

He stared like that for several minutes. Then he spoke in a low voice to himself, as if talking to the man inside the glass: “Your name is Zhou Ming. At least ‘on this side’, your name is Zhou Ming. You must remember that at all times.”

Only after that did he turn and walk away.

When he came to the all-too-familiar door, Zhou Ming took a deep breath and set his hand on the handle.

Besides the clothes on his body, he carried nothing extra. He took no food and no weapon for self-defense. This was the lesson left by his earlier “explorations”—he could not bring anything through this door except himself.

In fact, he even felt that he had to put a question mark behind this “self” as well, because…

Zhou Ming turned the handle and pushed the door open. A mass of gray-black fog that swelled and shrank like some kind of The Veil appeared before his eyes. In that shifting fog, he already seemed to hear the sound of waves in his ears.

As he stepped through that layer of fog, a slightly fishy, salty sea wind blew against his face. The vague, unreal sound of the waves became clear. A gentle rocking rose under his feet. After a brief spell of dizziness, Zhou Ming opened his eyes. Before him was a wide, empty wooden deck, tall masts standing under dark clouds, and a gently heaving sea beyond the rail, its edge nowhere in sight.

Zhou Ming lowered his head. What he saw was a body stronger than the one in his memories, a captain’s uniform whose fine workmanship and high cost were clear at a glance but whose style was completely unfamiliar, a pair of big, knobby hands, and, held in those hands, a black flintlock pistol with a classical, elegant look.

Yes, even his own “self” needed a question mark.

Chapter 2: the Vanished’s Captain

This was not the first time Zhou Ming crossed this door to the “other side”.

Ever since a few days ago, when Zhou Ming woke up and found that some kind of “phenomena” had trapped him in his room and a strange, heavy fog had covered the whole world, he had discovered the bizarre place on the other side of the door.

After all, that door was now the only exit from his “room”.

He still remembered the confusion and helplessness the first time he opened the door and saw a deck outside. He remembered even more clearly the shock and panic the first time he looked down and saw that his body had changed. But after that, in order to find a chance to break out of his situation, he had forced himself to boldly explore “this side” several times. Now, although he still had no idea what had really happened to him, and still did not understand what was going on with this strange, huge ship that had appeared outside his apartment door, he had at least gained some experience and a rough understanding of the ship.

As in the past few times, Zhou Ming forced himself, in as short a time as possible, to shake off the dizziness brought on by passing through the door. Then he immediately checked the condition of this body. He examined the short pistol in his hand, comparing every detail with his memory. In the end he confirmed that the things he carried were the same as when he last left the deck.

“…Looks like every time I pass through this door, the body ‘switches’ seamlessly… If only I could put a camera out here on the deck. Then I could check whether this body changes when I open the captain’s cabin door and go back to the apartment…

“Too bad objects from the two ‘worlds’ can’t pass through the door, so there’s no way to bring a camera over…

“But the phone in my apartment did record what happened when I passed through the door from that side. I really did walk through that black fog… so it really is that the body ‘changes’ into this form when it goes through the fog?”

Zhou Ming muttered to himself. He knew that standing on the deck and talking like this would look a bit ridiculous to anyone watching, but he had to make some noise. On this vast, empty, eerie ghost ship… he needed something to prove that he was still “alive”.

A fishy, salty sea wind blew across the deck and fluttered the dark blue captain’s coat of unknown material on his body. Zhou Ming let out a soft sigh, but he did not walk deeper across the deck. Instead, he turned around and looked at the door behind him.

He put his hand on the doorknob.

If he turned the knob and pushed the door inward, he would see a thick gray-black fog. If he walked through that fog, he would return to the single apartment where he had lived for many years.

He tightened his grip and yanked the door outward instead.

The slightly heavy oak door creaked. Behind it was a dim cabin. In the unclear light he could see fine tapestries hanging on the walls and shelves full of ornaments. There was a wide chart table in the center of the room. At

the far end of the room there was another small door, with a wine-red carpet laid in front of it.

If he pushed the door inward, he would return to his apartment. If he pulled it open, it led to the captain's cabin—and the latter was clearly the "normal facility" on this ship.

Zhou Ming stepped into the captain's cabin. As he passed the doorway, he habitually glanced to the left. A full-height mirror was fixed to the wall there, and in it he clearly saw what "Zhou Ming" looked like now.

It was a tall man with thick black hair and a stern short beard. His eye sockets were deep, and his face alone carried an air of authority that did not need anger to be frightening. He looked to be over forty, but his bold features and heavy gaze blurred any sense of age. The well-made captain's uniform he wore made the man in the mirror look even more special.

Zhou Ming rolled his neck and then made a face at the mirror. He thought of himself as an easygoing, friendly person, and the image in the mirror really did not match his temperament. But he quickly gave up, because he felt that the man in the mirror did not look any friendlier. Instead, he looked less like a stern captain and more like a psychopathic serial killer…

As Zhou Ming was doing all this, a faint clicking sound came from the direction of the chart table. He looked over without surprise and saw a wooden Goathead statue on the table slowly turning its face toward him. The dead wood seemed to come alive for a moment, and the obsidian eyes set in its wooden face stared gloomily this way.

The memory of his panic the first time he saw this eerie scene flashed through his mind, but Zhou Ming only curled the corner of his mouth. He walked toward the chart table, and the wooden Goathead on the table turned its neck bit by bit with him. A hoarse, gloomy voice came from its wooden body: "Name?"

“Duncan,” Zhou Ming said calmly. “Duncan Abnomar.”

The wooden Goathead’s voice instantly changed from hoarse and gloomy to warm and friendly: “Good morning, Captain. I’m very glad to see you still remember your own name. How is your mood today? How is your body today? Did you sleep well last night? I hope you had a good dream. Also, today is a fine day to set sail. The sea is calm, the wind is just right, cool and comfortable, and there are no annoying navy ships or noisy crew members. Captain, do you know what a noisy crew member…”

“You are noisy enough already,” Zhou Ming said. Even though this was not his first time dealing with the eerie Goathead, he still felt his brain throb. He glared at the thing almost viciously and squeezed the word out between his teeth: “Quiet.”

“Oh, oh, oh, of course, Captain. You like quiet. Your loyal first mate, second mate, chief sailor, sailor, and lookout all in one knows this very well. There are many benefits to keeping quiet. There was once a man in the field of medicine… or maybe philosophy, or architecture…”

Now Zhou Ming felt not only his brain but even his bronchi starting to tremble. “I mean, I order you to be quiet!”

The moment the word “order” left his mouth, the Goathead finally fell silent.

Zhou Ming let out a small breath of relief and stepped over to sit in front of the chart table. For now, he was the “captain” of this empty ghost ship.

Duncan Abnomar. A strange name, a tongue-twisting surname.

The first time he stepped through that layer of gray-black fog and onto this ship, these facts had appeared in his mind. He knew that this body he had on “this side” was named Duncan. He knew he was the ship’s master. He

knew the ship was on a long voyage far beyond imagination. He knew these things, and only these things.

The memories left in his mind were so vague and thin that only those key fragments remained. All other details were blank. It was as if he knew the ship had some astonishing voyage planned, but had no idea where it was going. The ship's original master—the real "Duncan Abnomar"—seemed to have died a very, very long time ago.

And the things left in Zhou Ming's mind felt more like the last, deepest impressions a ghost captain had left in the world after completely dying.

Instinct told Zhou Ming that there was something very wrong behind this "Captain Duncan" identity. Especially since there were supernatural phenomena's on the ship—like a talking wooden Goathead—the mystery around Captain Duncan might mean some danger he had never even imagined. Yet he had to keep using this name in order to move safely around the ship.

Because, just like the wooden Goathead just now, certain things on the ship were constantly trying to verify the captain's identity.

Even the ship itself seemed to be checking the captain's identity at all times.

It felt like some kind of safety measure, as if the ship's captain might forget his own name at any moment, and once he forgot it, something extremely terrible and dangerous would happen. So the ship had "checks" set up everywhere.

Zhou Ming did not know what would happen if "Captain Duncan" forgot his name, but he was sure that nothing good would come of giving the wrong name.

After all, even the wooden Goathead on the chart table alone did not look like a kind soul.

But as long as he wore the name Duncan Abnomar, everything on the ship seemed fairly mild and friendly.

Anyway, none of them looked very smart.

Zhou Ming—or maybe he should call himself Duncan now—ended his short moment of thought and memory, then looked at the enchanted sea chart spread out on the table.

However, there were no recognizable routes, markings, or land on the enchanted sea chart at all. There was not even an island. On the rough, thick sheet of parchment he could only see large patches of gray-white clumps constantly surging and rolling. Those gray-white, fog-like things seemed to cover whatever routes should have been on the paper. The only thing visible in the center of the enchanted sea chart was the faint silhouette of a ship looming in the thick mist.

In the several decades of his life, Duncan (Zhou Ming) had never had any experience sailing out to sea, but even someone who knew nothing about sea charts would know that a “normal” enchanted sea chart should not look like this.

Clearly, like the wooden Goathead on the table, this enchanted sea chart was also some kind of supernatural item. Duncan just had not yet figured out how to use it.

It seemed that once the captain’s attention finally stayed on the enchanted sea chart, the Goathead that had been quiet on the table for a long time started moving again. It began to make clicking sounds as the wood rubbed, and its neck twisted back and forth in small movements. At first it turned rather carefully, but soon the clicking grew impossible to ignore. In the end, its whole head started shaking on the base as if someone had turned on a vibration mode.

Afraid that if it kept twitching it would start drilling sparks into his chart table, Duncan finally could not help glancing at it. “Speak.”

“Yes, Captain. I must repeat: today really is a fine day to set sail. The Vanished, as always, is waiting for your orders! Shall we raise the sails?”

Chapter 3: Lost at the Border

The wooden Goathead's hard, dark face stared at Duncan sitting behind the chart table, and the obsidian eyes seemed to shine with an eerie light. In fact, the thing had no ability to show expressions at all, but Duncan clearly read a kind of expectation on that wooden face.

In fact, this was not the first time the Goathead had urged him to "set sail". Every time he came here, the Goathead would urge him like this.

He even felt that the whole ship kept urging him, pushing him to end this blind drifting at sea as soon as possible and set sail back onto the right course.

But Duncan fell silent. Shadows passed over his naturally imposing face. As he pondered in silence, he clearly saw two problems:

First, he was the only person on the entire ship, and the ship was insanely huge. As a sailing ship, the vessel called "the Vanished" was at least one hundred and fifty to two hundred meters long, by Duncan's rough estimate. To handle such a giant, you would need dozens, even hundreds of experienced sailors. How was he supposed to sail it alone?

Second, even putting those professional issues aside, there was still one key problem blocking his voyage—he did not know how to sail a ship at all.

Duncan grew a little anxious. He tried to imagine what would happen if he asked this eerie and noisy Goathead in front of him to teach him how to steer a ship. After imagining it, he felt even more anxious.

But the Goathead did not know what its captain was thinking. It just asked: “Captain, do you have any concerns? If you are worried about the Vanished’s condition, you can rest easy. The Vanished is always ready to sail with you to the world’s end. Or are you worried that today is an unlucky day to depart? I know a little of divination. Which kind of divination do you trust more? The stars, incense, crystals, all are fine. Speaking of crystals, do you remember…”

Duncan forced the muscles in his face to stay tight, holding back the urge to fight the Goathead to the death. He spoke in a low voice: “I’ll go to the deck and check the situation first—you stay here and be quiet.”

“As you wish—but I must remind you, the Vanished has been drifting blindly for far too long. You must take command of her as soon as possible and bring this voyage back on course…”

The Goathead finished speaking, and with more sounds of wood scraping, it finally returned to its original posture.

At once, Duncan felt as if the whole world had quieted down.

He let out a soft breath, and the throbbing in his head slowly calmed. Then he picked up the flintlock pistol on the table and rose to leave the captain’s cabin.

He had found this old-looking flintlock pistol while exploring the ship. Along with it, he had also found a single-handed sword, which now hung at his waist. These two items were his only sense of security when he moved around the ship.

During his explorations over the past few days, he had spent a long time roughly learning how to use them—even though, up to now, he had not seen any living creature on the ship besides himself.

Talking “objects” did not count.

The fishy, salty sea wind blew into his face, and his slightly irritated mood calmed with it. He stepped onto the deck outside the captain's cabin and instinctively looked up at the sky.

Thick dark clouds still covered all the sky he could see. There were no sun, moon, or stars in the clouds, only a muddy daylight covering the endless sea.

This scene had lasted a long time. In fact, ever since the day Duncan came to the ship, this was the only sky he had seen. It even made him wonder if this world had no normal weather at all, and whether these packed clouds were the eternal sky over this sea.

Duncan turned around and saw the door of the captain's cabin standing quietly there. On the beam above the door, a line of words was carved in letters he did not recognize. When he focused his gaze on them, however, their meaning appeared clearly in his mind:

"The Lost Ones' Door."

"The Lost Ones' Door… the Vanished, hm," Duncan muttered to himself, then added with a hint of self-mockery, "This ship really does have a good name."

Then he walked around the captain's cabin and climbed the stairs along the edge of the deck to the upper deck at the stern. There was a wooden platform here, the place with the best view on the ship aside from the lookout.

A heavy black ship's wheel waited quietly on the platform for someone to take the helm.

Duncan frowned. For some reason, he suddenly felt a sense of urgency and restlessness, and it seemed to appear out of nowhere the moment he saw the wheel.

He had never felt this way in any of his previous visits here!

As if answering the anxiety in his heart, a sudden, chaotic wind swept across the deck, and the calm sea around them instantly broke into waves. The wind and waves were still not enough to truly affect the huge Vanished, but alarms rang in Duncan’s mind. The next second, driven by his instincts, he looked toward the bow.

On the sea directly ahead of the Vanished, between the hazy sky and water, a boundless high wall of white fog rose up as if from nowhere, like a barrier reaching the heavens, making his eyes widen at once!

It was white fog that looked as if it wrapped around and cut off the entire world, a sheer wall linking sky and sea and rolling toward them. More than its frightening size, what made Duncan (Zhou Ming) even more alert was that it instantly reminded him of the endless mist outside the windows of his apartment.

The Vanished was sailing straight toward that fog wall!

Duncan did not know what that dense fog was, or what lay inside it, but instinct told him it was extremely dangerous. His survival sense told him that being swallowed by that fog would be anything but good!

He rushed instinctively toward the platform with the helm—but a huge sense of helplessness fell over him at the same time. Even if he held the wheel, how could he alone steer this giant ship away from that fog wall?

But he still moved by instinct to stand before the wheel. Almost at the same moment, he heard a hoarse, gloomy voice come from a copper tube next to the wheel that was connected to the captain’s cabin. It was the Goathead’s voice—and this time, the eerie thing actually sounded a bit panicked:

“Captain, a Border Collapse has appeared ahead. We are approaching the limits of the Mortal Realm! Please adjust our course at once!”

Hearing the Goathead’s panicked voice, Duncan nearly burst into a curse—adjusting the course was easy to say. Why didn’t it conjure a hundred or so good brothers who could sail a ship and have them run this thing?

Then he looked up toward the masts and saw only a few bare poles standing on the deck. A wave of sorrow rose in his heart. Forget raising sails; the truth was that the ship did not even have sails. Those poles were completely empty!

In his agitation, he did not even have time to think carefully about the strange words the Goathead had just used. His instincts alone made him reach out and grab the wheel in front of him, which for some reason seemed to be trembling slightly.

For the first time in days, he had actively placed his hand on the Vanished’s wheel. Before this, the ship’s eerie condition and the Goathead’s constant urging had always left him full of doubts and resistance toward “taking the helm”. Now, he finally had no time left to hesitate.

He gripped the wheel tightly. His mind was blank, and he had no time to even think about how he could, alone, command an empty ghost ship.

The change came in the next instant.

A sound like mountains roaring and seas crashing exploded in Duncan’s mind. It was as if ten thousand cheering people stood on the shore sending off a ship, as if hundreds of shouting sailors on the deck were calling the captain’s name, with desolate sea songs and invisible stormy waves mixed in between.

A mass of green flame rose at the edge of his vision. Duncan instinctively looked at his hand and saw emerald fire burst from the Vanished’s wheel and sweep toward him with terrifying speed, spreading over his whole body in the blink of an eye.

In the blazing fire, his flesh-and-blood body suddenly became hollow and ghostly. The captain’s uniform turned tattered and ragged, as if it had been soaked in seawater for dozens or hundreds of years. Under the flesh that had suddenly become as unreal as a spirit form, Duncan could vaguely see his own bones. Flames danced on those crystal, jade-like bones, and the undying fire flowed through his body like water.

Yet he felt no pain or burning at all. In the roaring flames, he only felt his senses spreading out in all directions.

The fire swept down from the helm platform, flowed over the deck, over the rails, and over the masts. The flames wove together like a net, then rose from the deck as if breathing, climbing along the lonely masts and finally weaving between sea and fog into huge sails like misty gauze.

The Vanished had raised her sails at the collapsing border of the Mortal Realm.

Chapter 4: Spirit Realm Drag Racing

ghostly green flame burned fiercely across his body. Flesh and bone turned into a translucent spirit form in the blaze. In this flowing fire, Duncan gripped the helm of the Vanished, and his senses seemed to spread along the flames, reaching out until they covered the entire ship.

So it turned out the ship did not need a crew at all.

The Vanished could raise her sails by herself. As long as the captain held the helm, she could set off at any time.

When the eerie green flames had first flared up, Duncan had panicked for a moment. But in the past few days of exploration he had already seen more than one supernatural phenomenon on this ship. Those experiences forced him to calm down, and in those most critical seconds he did not let go of the wheel in his hands.

Now he finally felt sure that this flame was some kind of power that did not harm him. Whether his body could return to normal later or not, at least for now, this power of the flame was helping him control the ghost ship under his feet.

The cheering roar that had been surging through his mind faded like a receding tide. Duncan felt clearer-headed than ever. The Vanished sent him all kinds of indescribable sensations, like an extension of his own limbs. He still did not have the knowledge and experience a proper captain should have, but at least now he had the ability to control this ship alone.

The gauzy, mist-like spirit-form sails swelled on the masts. Numerous auxiliary jibs and side sails began to adjust their angles on their own. The airflow above the sea was in complete chaos, yet those spirit-form sails seemed to draw a unified driving force out of the formless, confused wind. The massive Vanished ended her aimless drifting and began to steady under the push of her sails.

Duncan tried turning the wheel in his hands. The solid feedback of force flowed into his mind. He felt the huge hull under his feet finally begin to turn, trying to move away from the endless bank of mist ahead.

But the turn still did not seem fast enough. That boundless wall of dense fog kept creeping closer. From the brass speaking tube beside the wheel came Goathead's sharp cry: "Attention, we are approaching the limit of the Mortal Realm… We are about to fall into the Spirit Realm! Captain, we need—"

"I'm working on it!" Duncan shouted, cutting Goathead off. "Instead of squawking down there, why don't you think of something useful to do!"

Goathead fell silent at once. Just when Duncan thought it had finally quieted down, the tube suddenly carried its hoarse, shrill, downright creepy scream again: "Come on! Come on! Come on!"

Duncan: "…?"

In that moment, everything around him suddenly felt unreal. He had accepted the strange things that had happened to him, accepted the supernatural power on this ship, even accepted that he was being slow-cooked over a low green flame. But he had never imagined that Goathead, which had seemed so eerily dangerous from the very start, would suddenly act like this… That cursed thing had always been unsettling, but right now it was just too bizarre.

But the rolling fog that kept closing in gave Duncan no time to think or complain. The Vanished had already begun to swing around at high speed—judging by her massive hull, this turning speed was practically a drift. Yet the distant fog bank seemed to be consciously chasing its prey. Thin shrouds of mist spread from its edges, and the haze expanded so fast that in almost an instant it covered all the space around the Vanished.

The moment thin mist rose from the sea's surface, Duncan clearly felt something strange change in the surroundings. The daylight suddenly dimmed. The once-blue seawater somehow filled with countless thin black threads. Those black threads floated up from beneath the surface like tangled strands of hair and, at a speed visible to the naked eye, stained the entire sea pitch black.

Shapes seemed to loom everywhere in the thin fog.

"We've fallen into the Spirit Realm!" Goathead's noisy, eerie cheer finally stopped. Its shout now sounded as if it came from an extremely distant place, laced with countless low, fine whispers, as if many malicious voices were circling around Duncan. "But the Vanished has not completely dropped yet—Captain, hold the helm. Before we sink into the abyssal Deep Sea, the Vanished still has power to hold her course. We can still get out!"

"That depends on me knowing where to steer!" Duncan growled under his breath. His voice mixed with the crackle of burning green flame, as if it came from hell itself. "I've lost my sense of direction!"

"Instinct, Captain, instinct!" Goathead shouted through the tube. "Your instinct is more accurate than the marks on the enchanted sea chart!"

Duncan: "…"

A wave of helplessness surged up in him, but Duncan no longer had the strength to argue with a cursed Goathead. Since the thing said to trust his

instinct, he would just charge ahead with it—

Following the faint feeling that lingered from before the mist rose, he gripped the wheel hard and turned it with all his strength toward the direction he believed in.

The Vanished howled from top to bottom in a series of eerie wails. Her massive hull traced a startling arc across the now completely black sea. Gale winds roared, mist swirled, and in the dim light and fog, something at the edge of Duncan's vision seemed to slowly emerge.

A second later he realized it was a ship—a white vessel a size smaller than the Vanished, with a black smokestack rising from the middle of her hull.

At the end of the Vanished's beautiful arc, that ship which had suddenly appeared from the fog was heading straight toward them—or rather, the Vanished was heading straight toward her.

Only one howl echoed in Duncan's heart: "Damn it, drag racing in the Spirit Realm just went wrong!"

He had explored this bizarre world for so long without seeing another living person. Why did a ship have to pop up now, of all times? What were the odds of this kind of two-way collision course?

…

Gales howled. Huge waves towered. The Boundless Sea was unleashing its terrifying might to the fullest. Before this natural power that could tear even an supernatural apart, the White Oak was squeezing the last bit of strength from her steam turbines to fight against death.

The gray-haired captain, Lawrence Creed, stood in the wheelhouse. The sturdy walls and glass windows of the bridge gave him no sense of safety at all. He gripped the helm with both hands, and the White Oak's dying groans

and convulsions seemed to surge straight into his mind through the gears and linkages behind the wheel.

Through the wide windows he clearly saw incredible waves rising outside the hull. But more terrifying than those waves was the strange dense fog rising and spreading over the distant sea, and the faint black lightning flickering inside it.

The White Oak was the most advanced steamship in the world, but no matter how advanced a machine was, it could only ensure surging power in “normal” seas. Now, however, the ship and her captain were facing the collapsing border of the Mortal Realm and the bone-deep chill spreading up from the bottom of the world, from the foul palaces of those evil Gods.

“Captain! The priest can’t hold on much longer!”

The first mate’s shrill shout came from the side. Lawrence heard a murky, hoarse echo in the man’s voice. He then looked toward the front of the bridge. On the prayer stand, the censer was sending up an ominous purple-black flame. The respectable and loyal clergyman in the deep-blue robe sat before the censer, his whole body shaking. Blood covered his mouth and nose, and madness and clarity alternated constantly in his eyes.

Lawrence’s heart sank.

He knew that respectable priest was still standing on the side of humankind, using his last bit of devout faith and his pure, holy soul to resist the call from the depths of the world. But this endurance was already at its limit. The purple-black smoke rising from the censer was proof that the corruption had already broken through the prayers.

Once the priest collapsed, every sober mind on this ship might turn into a door leading to the Abyssal Deep Sea, or even to Subspace.

“Captain!”

The first mate's voice came again from the side, but Lawrence cut him off. The middle-aged captain's face was filled with resolve: "Temporarily shut down the Holy beacon. We sink into the Spirit Realm!"

The first mate froze, dumbfounded. This man, who had spent half his life making a living at sea, seemed unable to believe his ears: "Captain?!"

"We sink into the Spirit Realm—this way we can at least avoid the fiercest wave of the Border Collapse for ten minutes, and the priest will have a chance to recover," Lawrence repeated the order in a tone that allowed no doubt, adding only a brief explanation. "Carry out my command."

The first mate opened his mouth, as if wanting to say more, but then he gritted his teeth: "You're the captain!"

The crew began to carry out the captain's orders at once. Lawrence, still steering personally, took a deep breath. Deep in the hold, the Holy beacon was slowly going dark. He could feel the invisible protective field around the White Oak rapidly weakening. Without the sacred relic's protection, the ship was sinking bit by bit into the layer between the Mortal Realm and the Abyssal Deep Sea—the "Spirit Realm" in between.

Thin mist appeared on the surrounding sea, and the water slowly turned black.

It was very dangerous, but in history there had been ships that returned from a Spirit Realm state to the Mortal Realm. As a member of the Explorer Association, he had read countless books on this subject and all kinds of "survival guides" written by survivors.

How much worse could it get? All he needed to do was let the White Oak hide from one wave of the storm at the edge of the Spirit Realm, then use the surging power of her advanced steam turbines to pull off a risky "Spirit

Realm drift". If luck still favored him, he could lead his crew back to the Mortal Realm.

Then he would hurry to hand that damned "Anomaly 099" in the cargo hold over to the Governor of the city-state of Pland, and for the rest of his life he would never again wade into the authority's muddy waters.

It could not get any worse.

Lawrence comforted himself like this.

Then he saw, on the suddenly darkened sea in the distance, a three-masted sailing ship a full size larger than the White Oak abruptly appear. With a certain unstoppable momentum, it carved a breathtaking arc and came crashing straight toward them…

Captain Lawrence stared blankly ahead.

"…Fuck."

Chapter 5: Crossed Paths

The enormous shadow rolled in to crush them, and everyone on the White Oak saw this moment that would stay with them for the rest of their lives.

It was an ancient, awe-inspiring three-masted warship. In this age when steamships were no longer anything special, that sailing warship emerging from the dense fog looked so old it might have stepped out of an oil painting from a century ago. Her masts rose high, her sides were steep, and ghostly green fire burned across her black wooden hull like restless souls. Enormous sails billowed in the void, filled with howling phantoms and layers of flame. A scene like this appeared only in the most terrifying shipwreck legends, even on the dreadful Boundless Sea.

“We’re going to crash!!!”

Some of the crew cried out. These men, who made their living at sea and were known for their bravery and roughness, still lost their composure before such a giant. They shouted and ran. Some tried to find shelter on the deck, some clung to anything that could hold them in place, and some even dropped to their knees amid the pitching waves to pray with unprecedented devotion, chanting the names of the storm goddess Gamona or Bartok, the Lord of Death.

On the Boundless Sea, the Gods’ divine blessing had already faded, but only these two True Gods still had the power to watch over all their children alike.

But not all the crew lost their calm. The ship's first mate immediately looked to the captain he trusted most. He knew that sailing the Boundless Sea was full of danger, and an experienced captain was always the key to deciding a ship's fate. Lawrence had set foot on the ocean for more than thirty years. The old captain, now over fifty, might not be as strong as in his youth, but the experience that had kept him alive on this vast ocean might still win everyone a slim chance to live.

The ship emerging from the dense fog clearly was not a normal vessel sailing the world of the Mortal Realm. It looked more like something that had risen from the Spirit Realm, or from somewhere "deeper". If it was some kind of supernatural manifestation, then maybe they could use some supernatural power to fight it.

Old captains who sailed the Boundless Sea all had at least some experience dealing with supernatural manifestations.

Yet the first mate saw only fear and shock on the captain's face.

The old captain held the wheel without moving, as if he had not even noticed that the entire ship was already swallowed by the shadow. He stared fixedly at the oncoming hull, the muscles of his face so tight they looked carved from stone. At last he forced out a few words through his teeth, colder than the wind on the Frost Sea: "…It's the Vanished…"

"C-Captain?!" The first mate was startled by the name drifting into his ears. Like everyone who made a living on the Boundless Sea, he had heard that name from many older, more experienced, and more superstitious crewmen. "What did you say?! That—"

"The Vanished!!!"

Captain Lawrence seemed not to hear the first mate at all. He only clutched the White Oak's wheel with all his strength and let out a hoarse roar, as if he

wanted to scream at something. Almost as soon as his shout fell, the towering hull of the Vanished finally touched the White Oak's bow.

Almost all the sailors screamed.

Yet the earth-shaking impact they were braced for never came. The gigantic ship wreathed in green flames passed through like a vast phantom, its roaring blaze sweeping across the White Oak's deck. Thick hull, gloomy cabins, dim corridors, a keel and beams all burning with fire… The sailors stared in terror as they watched themselves crash into the phantom of that ghost ship, while the green flames burning on the ghost ship swept past them like a net of fire.

Lawrence also watched that blaze howl toward him, but before it reached him, he first saw it sweep over the first mate in front of him. The first mate's body suddenly turned into an illusory spirit form within the unreal flame, and the bones inside that spirit form burned like firewood. He also saw the priest by the prayer stand ahead. The flames on the priest flickered weakly, as if the God behind him was still using a thin trace of divine blessing to shield him from being devoured by the Vanished.

Then the flames reached Lawrence as well. He saw his own body undergo the same change. A powerful sense of weariness, obedience, and fear flooded his whole being. The ocean amulet he wore next to his body began to work, a feeling of heat and coolness alternating to barely keep his reason intact. With what little clarity he had left, he "passed through" the Vanished's cabins and corridors.

Gloomy, oppressive cabins rushed toward him and then swept past. Ropes mottled with rot and barnacles coiled around ancient wooden pillars that burned with green flame. He saw a vast cargo hold, where all kinds of uncanny objects that should have been buried in the Deep Sea lay quietly.

He saw a luxurious cabin with a wooden Goathead set on the table in its center.

That Goathead turned, gazing coldly into Lawrence’s eyes.

At last Lawrence used all his strength to lift his head. He saw the figure holding the helm. Beside the classic ship’s wheel stood a tall figure in a black mariner’s uniform, as imposing and terrifying as the master of a nightmare. That figure ruled all the ghostly flames, and even the sea already sunk into the depths of the Spirit Realm seemed cowed by his presence, torn open behind him.

Lawrence closed his eyes in resignation. He knew he was already part of the Vanished now. That nightmare captain needed sacrificial victims to feed his endless emptiness and loneliness.

But the next second, he forced himself to open his eyes again. It felt as if all the courage and madness of his life had gathered into these few moments. Recalling what he had learned from books and legends, he looked at the terrifying captain standing on the Vanished with an attitude as frank and calm as he could manage.

“You don’t need to take everyone—take me and let my crew go.”

But the tall figure did not answer. He only turned his gaze over coldly. There seemed to be a hint of curiosity in his eyes, as if he were wondering why a tiny mortal captain dared to bargain with him.

Lawrence finally could not hold back and let out a roar: “They all have wives and children!!”

The figure standing on the Vanished finally reacted. He stared in Lawrence’s direction and seemed to say something, but just then a loud roaring rose from the side. In the howl of wind, Lawrence only heard a vague noise and could not make out a single word.

The answer from the Vanished was blown away by the roar of the waves—

“What did you say?! The wind’s too loud, I can’t hear you!!”

The next second, a huge clamor crashed into Lawrence’s ears, full of wind, waves, and the shouts of sailors outside the door. Out of the corner of his eye he saw emerald flames fading quickly, and the Vanished’s last lingering phantom dissipated from the air like fog.

Lawrence sucked in a deep breath, then noticed that his hands, which the green flames had burned away before, had returned to normal. Everyone else in the bridge had also turned back into flesh and blood. The devout priest was lying by the prayer stand, gasping for breath and constantly chanting the holy name of the storm goddess Gamona. The ominous purple-black smoke in the censer slowly dispersed, and pure white smoke rose from the brass lid.

It took Lawrence a long time to steady his breathing. Then he looked around in doubt, as if he could not believe that nightmare was really over, until the first mate’s voice came from the side: “Captain! That ship—the Vanished has left!”

Lawrence looked dazed. After a few seconds he finally muttered to himself: “…He actually spared us?”

The first mate did not catch it for a moment: “Captain? What did you say?”

“Captain Duncan…” Lawrence murmured without thinking, then slapped himself as if he had accidentally spoken some forbidden word. He suddenly raised his head to look at the first mate. “Roll call, now! See who’s missing on the ship!”

The first mate nodded at once and moved to leave, but Lawrence immediately called him back: “And see if there’s anyone extra on board!”

The first mate froze, then understood. A trace of fearful suspicion appeared in his eyes. He took a deep breath, quietly whispered the name of the storm goddess, and then rushed out onto the deck.

On the White Oak, still sailing in a Spirit Realm state, the assembly bell rang like a death knell.

Chapter 6: The Missing “Cargo”

The assembly bell rang. After the sharp peal of the bell came the messy, panicked footsteps of the sailors, while Lawrence stayed in the bridge with the second mate and the priest, Mr. Ron, who still had not caught his breath.

The old captain looked out at the sea through the window. The White Oak was still at Spirit Realm depth. Fog coiled over the sea outside the rail, and the water was still black as ink. But the storm had stopped, and the terrifying Vanished had disappeared. It gave a person the illusion that the storm, and even the collapse of the Mortal Realm border, had all been brought by that ghost ship, and now all the disasters had gone away from the White Oak along with that ship.

Lawrence thought of the terrible legends about the Vanished and Captain Duncan Abnomar. He thought of the fleet swallowed by the Mortal Realm border more than a century ago, and of the ships that had sunk into the Abyssal Deep Sea, after encounters with the Vanished. Suddenly he felt that this was not impossible at all.

But no matter what, the Vanished had left, and the surrounding waters had briefly returned to calm. Although they were still at dangerous Spirit Realm depth, at least he and his crew had a chance to catch their breath.

Next, Lawrence had to find out exactly what the Vanished had taken from the White Oak, or what it had left on board.

And he had to find out as soon as possible.

As long as there were hidden dangers, he did not dare to let the ship surface into the Mortal Realm. Certain things brought out from the Spirit Realm could cause terrible corruption in the Mortal Realm. But if they stayed too long at Spirit Realm depth, he and his crew would still suffer irreversible effects.

Listening to the noise coming from the deck, Lawrence suddenly lifted his head from his thoughts. He looked at the priest, who was sitting before the censer and whose face looked a little better, and asked with a very serious expression: “Mr. Ron, how stable are we now?”

The priest coughed twice, then took a small, finely made spirit compass from his robe. Its surface was engraved with many symbols of the sea and holy signs. With a snap, he pressed open the metal lid. The pointer on the spirit compass began to spin wildly, then finally stopped and settled in one place.

“We are staying on the surface layer of the Spirit Realm, a bit closer to the Mortal Realm. The influence from the depth of the Abyssal Deep is very weak…” The priest watched the pointer on the spirit compass and suddenly looked a little puzzled. “Strange… we are completely stable here. With the sacred relic shut down, there is almost no tendency to sink any further… cough, cough…”

“Maybe that one ‘hit’ from the Vanished knocked us onto a safe route instead,” Lawrence said with a wry smile, shaking his head as he tried to use a cold joke to lighten the mood. “I heard there are subtle balance points in the Spirit Realm that let things from the Mortal Realm avoid the pull of the deep layers…”

“Captain, that joke was far too cold,” the priest said, coughing twice again. Although he had caught his breath, his condition was still far from good. “Cough… in any case, what happened today must be reported to the

Church. The appearance of the Vanished is never a small matter. For the past decades there have always been reports of encounters with the Vanished, but afterward they were all proved to be just the crew's nonsense, or group hallucinations caused by Visions going into a runaway state. But today we truly saw it with our own eyes… Goddess above, once you return to Pland, you had better be ready for a long time without sailing again."

"I understand. Neither the Church nor the city-state authority will allow a ship that has just suffered a Visions disaster to go back to sea. It is for everyone's safety. And I have more than the Church to report to: the city-state, the Explorer Association… sigh, and my terrible wife…" Captain Lawrence pressed a hand to his forehead, let out a long sigh, then waved his hand. "Enough about that. You need to rest now. Until we return to port, this ship will need the Goddess's blessing."

The priest nodded lightly, and very soon, the first mate, who had only just left, returned to the bridge.

"There is no one missing and no one extra on board," the first mate reported at once before the captain could even ask. "I personally checked the sailors assembled on deck and went to the boiler room to check the artificers who stayed there. They could all accurately recite the name of the God they worship. They are alive, no doubt about it."

"Not a single person missing?" Lawrence widened his eyes. This should have been good news, but he could not believe the report. "What about the Holy beacons?"

"The sacred relic is normal too," the first mate answered at once. "The navigator is preparing incense and oils, waiting for your order to restart the sacred relic."

Lawrence listened, torn between shock and doubt, and could not help muttering softly again: "Did he really spare this ship?"

“Good luck smiled on us, Captain,” the first mate said, spreading his hands. “We did not lose anything. Maybe that terrifying ghost captain was just passing by. He might have only crashed into us by accident.”

“Do you believe that yourself?” Lawrence glared at his first mate. “If good luck really smiled on us, we would never have run into…”

He had only spoken halfway when hurried footsteps suddenly sounded outside the door. A moment later, someone pushed the bridge door open. The boatswain appeared before Lawrence, dripping with sweat. The tall man’s face was full of fear.

“Captain! Anomaly 099 is gone!”

The bridge fell silent at once. Everyone stared at one another. But for some reason, after a brief moment of shock, Lawrence suddenly felt as if a weight had lifted from his heart.

Good. After an encounter with the Vanished, the ship had finally shown that something was wrong. That, at least, felt right.

But he quickly controlled his expression. As he walked toward the door, he hurriedly told the first mate to take the wheel, and ordered the boatswain to lead the way.

Hurried footsteps echoed through the corridors of the White Oak. Soon, guided by the boatswain, Lawrence reached the deepest part of the steamship.

A special compartment appeared before his eyes.

The door of this compartment was covered in dense occult studies symbols. The heavy, pitch-black door looked as if it had been cast from a single block of black iron. The mysterious symbols stretched from the edge of the doorframe all the way out into the corridor, faintly forming some kind of closed cage meant to bind whatever was stored in the room.

Lawrence glanced at the door and confirmed that neither it nor the surrounding symbols showed any sign of damage. Then he looked up. The “sacred relic room” that held the Holy beacon was directly above the sealed vault. That beacon was the key to keeping the ship from the influence of the deep layers, and it also served as the second safeguard that maintained the sealed vault. Even while shut down, it should still have kept the vault’s barrier intact.

Yet with both layers of protection intact, the contents of the sealed vault, the most critical cargo the White Oak was escorting on this voyage, Anomaly 099 – the Doll, the “spirit coffin” – had disappeared.

Lawrence took a deep breath, stepped forward, opened the sealed vault’s door, and pushed the heavy slab wide.

Inside the sealed vault, the lights were bright. The gas lamps hanging from the four pillars lit the center of the room with almost no shadows. But the “cargo” that should have been placed there had vanished without a trace. Only a few crisscrossing chains were left, along with some gray-white ash scattered on the floor around them.

The boatswain’s voice came from behind Lawrence: “According to the containment rules for Anomaly 099, the lights in this room must stay on, and every two hours a crew member comes in to tighten the chains around the spirit coffin and scatter bone ash on the floor. But when that… ghost ship appeared, everything turned chaotic. The sailor on duty did not come in on time. He was about seven minutes late, and when he arrived, he found that Anomaly 099 was gone…”

“Being only seven minutes late would not push that thing into a runaway state,” Lawrence said, frowning and shaking his head. “At most the containment would weaken and act up. In the worst case, the coffin would be running around inside this room. The layers of seals here and the

restraint from the Holy beacon are not for show. Right now, the problem is that it has disappeared. The cargo has left this ship. That has nothing to do with that sailor."

The boatswain looked a little nervous. "Then you mean…"

"It must have been the Vanished," Lawrence said in a deep voice. "That 'captain' took Anomaly 099 away…"

He paused for a moment and let out a soft sigh. "Maybe we should feel lucky. The Vanished only ever takes what it wants. That captain came for Anomaly 099, not for our lives."

The boatswain looked at his captain's face, then at the empty sealed vault. After a long time, he finally asked hesitantly: "Then… we have lost such an important piece of cargo. How are we going to explain it to the city-state authority…"

Lawrence glanced at the boatswain and slapped his shoulder hard.

"The Vanished counts as a calamity. We have maritime insurance."

"…Will the insurance company pay for that?"

"If they do not pay, we will have the Explorer Association put out a new bounty on the Vanished…"

"Captain, are you not being a bit anxi…"

"Shut up."

Chapter 7: Doll

The blazing green flames were slowly fading, and the sea around them was beginning to calm.

After confirming with Goathead that the Vanished had left the dangerous waters and that they could now sail on their own, Duncan took his hand off the dark helm. He lowered his head. What came into view was his body, restored to flesh and blood, and the deck of the Vanished, returned to normal after the green flame went out.

Yet in some unseen way, he felt that many things had changed.

He could feel that the moment he had grasped the Vanished's wheel, something had shifted. The emerald flame had bound him to this ship, and even to this sea. Even though the flame had now retreated, he could still feel that invisible link and sense every detail of the great vessel beneath his feet.

Duncan slowly closed his eyes. He heard faint whispers coming from the deep, dim corridors inside the Vanished, whispers that carried a strange sense of closeness. He saw that the consecrated lantern in the captain's cabin had lit itself at some point, a ghastly white light flickering inside its glass shade. He heard the sound of waves beating against the hull, and under those waves there seemed to be deep eyes watching. But whenever he tried to find the source of that gaze, it hid itself, as if it had a will of its own…

Duncan opened his eyes and let out a light breath. The spirit form sails on the Vanished's masts, thin as gauze and mist, billowed in answer. He walked toward the stairs leading up to the deck, and the ropes beside the stairs writhed to either side, opening a path for him.

He understood now. Only after he chose to take the wheel had he truly become the captain of this ship.

"Captain, we are rising from the edge of the Spirit Realm and will soon return to the Mortal Realm," Goathead's voice came from beside him, but this time it was not through the brass pipes used for communication on the ship. It appeared directly in Duncan's mind. When it spoke of serious matters it sounded much more solemn, and far less noisy. "We were lucky. At our deepest we only brushed the bottom layer of the Spirit Realm. We were almost untouched by the influence of the Abyssal Deep."

Mortal Realm, Spirit Realm, Abyssal Deep Sea, and, deeper still, Subspace… These strange words, which had appeared before him again and again, floated through Duncan's mind. He knew they pointed toward the true nature of this eerie world, but he still did not know what they really meant.

However, when he listened to Goathead call him "Captain", Duncan always felt a subtle change in its tone. He even suspected that now, even if he revealed the identity of "Zhou Ming", Goathead would still obey his orders. This was the change brought by taking the wheel and successfully returning from the green flame.

But after a brief hesitation, he still did not rashly try it. Nor did he ask Goathead about the Spirit Realm, the Abyssal Deep Sea, or Subspace.

If it had been a few days earlier, he really would have sunk into anxiety and unease, and would have been desperate to figure out his situation. Now, he did not seem to be in such a hurry.

In this world there were other “people”, other ships, a society with order, and other civilizations. That alone was enough for him to grow many hopes for the future, and even to form some plans, though they were still quite vague.

As his thoughts wandered, Duncan recalled the details of the encounter with the ship that had suddenly emerged from the thick fog. He remembered the ship’s striking smokestack, and the mechanical structures that had appeared directly in his mind when it crossed paths with the Vanished.

“That was a mechanically powered ship… while the Vanished looks like a sailing warship from an earlier age…” Duncan muttered to himself. “But it was not completely a mechanical ship either…”

There were compartments on that ship whose purpose he did not understand, laid out like sites for some sort of ritual. On the keel he had seen many strange patterns and symbols. They looked like decorations, but went far beyond what decoration should need.

“Goathead,” Duncan called suddenly. He did not know Goathead’s real name, so he instinctively used the name in his mind. “When we ‘crossed’ that ship just now, the man who looked like the captain was shouting at me. What did he say?”

Goathead seemed not to care at all how the captain addressed it. It accepted the name happily and answered at once: “The wind and waves were too strong. I did not hear clearly.”

“You did not hear either?” Duncan frowned. “…I kept feeling that his expression was so tragic, like he was ready to die together with me. Whatever he was shouting should have been very important.”

“Wanting to die with you is a normal reaction for humans, especially for sailors at sea. It is nothing to make a fuss about. And their shouts before

they, like ants, try to shake a giant tree are even less worth your attention…”

Goathead’s answer sounded perfectly natural to it. Duncan, who was walking up the stairs to the deck, almost missed a step. His mouth twitched in shock. “Wanting to die with me is humans’ normal reaction?”

As soon as he said it, he felt that something was wrong. It sounded like he was exposing flaws in his identity as “captain”, revealing how little he knew about “himself”. Maybe the green flame had drained him too much, or maybe the feeling of merging with the Vanished had dulled his caution. Whatever the reason, it made Duncan tense at once. Yet Goathead seemed not to notice at all.

“They fear you. That is normal,” Goathead said, his tone even sounding a bit proud. “Anyone who sails the Boundless Sea should fear you, just as they fear those old Gods and the Shadows in Subspace. Speaking of Shadows, do you know that a great engineer – or maybe an agronomist, or a gourmet – once said…”

Duncan wisely did not take up the topic. He was worried that if the conversation went on, he would not be able to keep up the act. [Of course, the main reason was that he really did not want to talk to Goathead. Once someone responded, its chatter grew at a geometric rate.] And in the next second, something else on the deck drew his attention.

“…What is that?” Duncan stood at the edge of the deck, staring in astonishment at the thing by the door of the captain’s cabin.

It was a wooden box a bit longer than a person, built with very fine craftsmanship. Unknown dark wood had been joined together so tightly that no seam showed and then reinforced with metal that looked like gold. Along the edges of the box he could see complex carved patterns, like writing, or like pictographs that had been deliberately twisted. This box was

definitely not something from the Vanished. Duncan had not seen it when he left the captain's cabin earlier.

After a brief silence, Goathead's voice sounded: "…I do not recognize it, but it should be spoils of war…"

"Spoils?" Duncan did not react at first. He walked around the box twice. "Why does this thing look like a coffin, only much fancier than a normal coffin… Wait, spoils? You mean this thing was 'taken' from that ship just now?!"

"A successful hunt, Captain," Goathead said in a very serious tone, with something that sounded like flattery mixed in. "You always return fully loaded from every voyage. This is just your usual performance."

Duncan opened his mouth without thinking. He felt that he had never planned to take anything from that ship. How did this count as a hunt or as "returning fully loaded"?

But then he thought again. Saying that out loud might not fit his image as "captain". More importantly, that mechanical ship had already disappeared into the thick sea fog. Thinking of that white-bearded captain's eyes, almost bursting with rage as he glared at him like a man ready to die together, Duncan felt there was no way to send this thing back. He could only swallow all his words.

He stood before the ornate wooden box that looked like a coffin and noticed that the lid seemed loose. It looked as if it would open with a single pull.

After hesitating for a moment, he placed his hand on the lid of the box. At the very least, he had to figure out what his little "Spirit Realm joyride" had brought onto the ship.

His body was stronger than he had imagined, and the lid was lighter than he had thought. With just a little force, the dark lid lifted, opening a crack, then

swung fully open under his hand.

Duncan stared into the box, dumbfounded.

“A person?”

Inside the box lay a beautiful young woman. Her silver-white hair spread inside like liquid mercury. Her features were flawless, and she carried a faint air of noble detachment. She wore a gorgeous purple-black court dress, and her hands were folded on her chest, as if she were in a long sleep.

Perfect, like a Doll.

“No, wait. This really is a Doll!”

As he looked closely, Duncan suddenly noticed the inhuman structure of her joints.

Chapter 8: the Sun

A doll. A doll so delicate and lifelike that Duncan almost failed to tell it was not a real person at first glance. She lay quietly inside the ornate wooden chest, like a lady sleeping in a spirit coffin, waiting for someone to wake her.

Duncan really felt she would open her eyes in the next second.

But it was only an illusion. The doll just lay there in the chest, not reacting to anything around her.

Duncan watched this strange… “thing” with wary care. A doll by itself was nothing unusual, but her face looked too close to a real human, and that coffin-like wooden box gave him a gut feeling of danger. When he thought about how this chest had appeared on the Vanished for no reason at all, it was no wonder he became so alert.

After watching for a long time, Duncan finally felt sure that the gorgeous Brother doll in the chest was not going to suddenly jump up and give him a fright. Only then did he relax a little. He frowned and asked Goathead: “What do you think is going on here?”

“This should be the important cargo that ship was escorting earlier,” Goathead answered at once. Before, it had said it did not recognize the strange wooden chest that had suddenly appeared on deck, but its experience with matters at sea was clearly richer than that of Duncan, this fake captain. “There are symbols on the outside of the chest that point to a God, and there are bolts around it for fastening chains. That may mean it

used to be under some kind of seal. Carrying a sealed object across the Boundless Sea is extremely risky. That ship must have had some backing."

"A seal?" Duncan's eyelids twitched. He looked at the chest lid, which he had already pushed fully open. When it arrived on the Vanished, the lid had already been broken, which was why he had been able to move it so easily. He did not understand much about seals and that sort of thing, but he was sure whatever seal this thing once had was now gone. "So this thing is dangerous?"

"It is very dangerous to those fragile ordinary people, but I do not think it can threaten you," Goathead said. "An Anomaly that can be sealed by human skill is not something that could resist Captain Duncan's power."

Duncan stayed silent, his face serious, but his thoughts churned.

Goathead's flattery sounded nice enough. If he really had been this "Captain Duncan", he might even have believed it. But he was not, so inside he was panicking.

Because Goathead's words had made it clear that the doll lying in that coffin was a "dangerous item"! It was only harmless to the real captain!

Even though he now carried Captain Duncan's name, and even seemed to be using the man's body and some of his power, Zhou Ming had a clear idea of his own limits. He did not believe this alone made him the same as the "real Captain Duncan".

He still knew far too little about this world, this ship, and even the body he now used.

On top of that, he had sharply noticed a new strange word in Goathead's speech just now—"Anomaly".

Anything out of the ordinary could be called an anomaly. It sounded like an ordinary word, but the way Goathead had stressed it made him faintly sense

that, here, this word had some special meaning.

Maybe in this world, the word “Anomaly” did not just mean something “unusual”. It also pointed to a certain category of things. For example… a doll lying in a coffin.

Sadly, he had no good excuse to ask about something that probably counted as “common knowledge” here.

He sighed inwardly, feeling again how he needed to collect information and build up knowledge very carefully. Then Duncan frowned and gave the doll one last look, as if making up his mind at last: “I should throw it back into the sea.”

He felt a trace of hesitation as he spoke. When he looked at the doll, that hesitation grew stronger.

It was not just because “the doll was pretty”, something that simple. It was because “she” really did look too much like a living person sleeping in a spirit coffin. When he thought of throwing her back into the sea, Duncan even felt as if he was tossing a living human off the ship.

But in the end, that very hesitation only hardened his resolve.

He already knew this world held many strange and eerie things. So far, all he had seen of it was this one ship, the Vanished, but even here he had already met the talking Goathead, a mast that could raise its own sails, lamps that never went out, that weird and dangerous sea, the chilling Spirit Realm, and endless sea fog…

Just now, he had even run into a mechanical ship sailing this eerie sea while carrying a sealed object. The thing that ship had been “guarding” had then somehow appeared on the deck of the Vanished.

As a rational and cautious person, he could not keep something so likely to hold strange, dangerous power just because the doll looked pretty.

Regret was regret, but Duncan still firmly closed the “coffin’s” lid again. Because he still did not feel at ease, he went into the cabin to find nails and a hammer, and carefully hammered a ring of iron nails all around the lid.

At last, he pushed the “spirit coffin” holding the doll to the edge of the deck.

Goathead’s voice sounded in his ears: “You may deal with your spoils as you wish, but I still humbly offer a suggestion. There is no need to be so careful. The Vanished has not added to its spoils in a long time…”

“Shut up.” Duncan cut off Goathead’s rambling with that simple reply.

Goathead fell silent. Duncan then kicked hard at the “spirit coffin” and sent it straight into the sea.

The heavy chest dropped straight down from the rail and plunged into the sea, which had already gone back to its normal color. After a dull splash, it floated back up and slowly drifted toward the stern of the Vanished.

Duncan watched the chest with his gaze as it drifted away on the waves. Only after it was completely hidden behind the stern did he finally let out a slow breath. Then he lifted his head and looked into the distance. The mist over the sea had completely cleared, and the blue ocean rose and fell gently around the Vanished.

The ship had fully left the Spirit Realm and returned to the Mortal Realm.

There was no sign at all on the nearby sea of the mechanical ship that had briefly crossed paths with the Vanished.

Duncan frowned slightly and did a quick estimate of how much time had passed since the ships met and how fast each one should be sailing.

From the way the sea now looked, that ship should not have vanished from sight so quickly.

“…Was this also because of this strange sea? Or was it tied to that so-called ‘Spirit Realm sailing’?” he wondered.

Duncan muttered to himself in his heart, but soon his attention was caught by something else—

He saw a line of golden light suddenly appear deep within the heavy clouds that had always hung over the sea.

Bright golden sunlight slowly spread out. The thick clouds, like heavy curtains, seemed to be brushed aside by an invisible hand and began to thin and melt away. The sea, which had been gloomy for who knew how long, was slowly lit by sunlight. Duncan stood at the bow of the Vanished, eyes wide, using his gaze to take in the sight of the clouds breaking up. In that moment, he suddenly felt a strange, hard-to-name emotion.

Ever since he had learned, days ago, that “this side” existed, ever since he had first explored this strange ship, those unbroken clouds had always covered the whole sea. He had almost come to believe this world simply had no sunlight at all, that it was meant to be forever overcast.

He had been parted from sunlight for too long. Even on the other side of the “door”, in Zhou Ming’s small studio apartment, the thick fog outside the window had long since hidden the Sun.

But now, the Boundless Sea had cleared.

After being away from sunlight for so long, he finally had the feeling of seeing the sky again in this world “on this side”.

Duncan took a deep breath without thinking and spread his arms toward the direction of the sunlight. The heavy clouds seemed to answer him, quickly thinning and fading away. At the brightest instant of the sky, a huge sphere covered in countless twisted streams of golden light came into Duncan’s view.

Duncan’s expression froze in that very moment, arms still spread to welcome the sunlight.

He stared at the sky, eyes wide. The sunlight was bright, but not as blinding as what he was used to. He could clearly see the thing hanging above. He saw the shell of the sphere, covered in countless tight, tangled lines. He saw the brilliant streams of light spilling out around it. And against the crossing glow, he saw two ring-shaped structures around the central sphere, laid out like concentric circles and slowly turning.

Duncan narrowed his eyes. He could just make out that the two rings seemed to be made up of countless fine and complex runes linked together, as if some supreme power had carved an eternal shackle into the sky, chaining “the Sun” in place.

Duncan did not get to embrace the sunlight he had longed for.

This world did not have sunlight at all.

“What is that?” he asked softly, his voice low and cold.

“That is, of course, the Sun, Captain,” Goathead said, as calm as always.

Chapter 9: Away and Back, Then Back Again

The sunlight was very bright.

If the glowing thing hanging in the sky really was the Sun, then its “sunlight”… was indeed very bright.

Duncan did not know how long he stared at the sky. Only when his eyes grew sore and aching did he finally drag his gaze down from the clouds. But the image of that “Sun” stayed burned into his retinas and deep in his mind. Even with his eyes closed, he could clearly recall it: the sphere glowing with pale gold light, the twisted streams of light curling around it, and the ring structures moving quietly around the sphere like concentric circles.

The Sun was not like this. It was not supposed to be like this. In the world he knew, even under the sky of another planet, the star hanging overhead would never look like that.

But now he had to accept the facts.

He was in a foreign land, far more distant than he had ever imagined.

Even the Sun had taken on a form he could not understand.

Duncan turned his head without thinking and looked at the door in front of the captain’s cabin.

If he pushed the door inward, he could return to the room where he had lived for many years, return to his small apartment.

But outside that apartment, the heavy fog had long since covered the whole world. The “home” he knew, in a way, had already shrunk down to that last thirty-square-meter room.

The “home” that seemed only a door-push away was, in truth, just another lonely boat drifting on the sea.

After a long silence, Goathead’s voice suddenly echoed in Duncan’s ears: “Captain, where are we going next? Do you have any plan for our voyage?”

A sailing plan? How could Duncan have something like that? He did want to draw up a proper plan to explore this world and fix the next legs of his journey, but he did not even have a normal enchanted sea chart. He did not know what lands existed in this world, what powers ruled them, or whether this endless ocean even had an edge.

Only a few hours ago he had just learned how to steer the Vanished at all.

Still, he fell into thought. A few minutes later, he spoke in his mind: “That ship that rammed into the Vanished earlier—where did it come from?”

“You wish to head for those city-states?” Goathead sounded a bit surprised, then quickly began to advise against it. “I suggest you do not go near the routes controlled by those city-states… at least not yet. You may be the great Captain Duncan, but the Vanished is not what it once was. Their city-states’ Garrison Navy and the Holy See’s Guard Corps would certainly do everything they could to resist your… attack.”

For a moment Duncan had nothing to say. He suddenly really wanted to know what kind of heaven-shaking crimes the “Captain Duncan” he had replaced had committed in the past, that just showing his face in the mortal

world now seemed enough to trigger a full twenty-five-man raid on the spot…

And from Goathead's roundabout wording, Duncan also realized that the current state of the Vanished and this "captain" of his was not as glorious as the spirit's usual praise made it sound. Was the reason the ghost captain and his ship lurked out on the high seas simply that they did not dare return to the civilized world's harbors?

So exile was just another way of saying "a trip to the end of the world", huh.

Duncan felt a bit troubled. He urgently needed a way to learn about this world. He had to find some means to make contact with its "civilized society". Whether it was to survive here in the long term or to solve the mysteries and return to the "home" he knew, he could not just keep drifting aimlessly on this endless sea. But the problem was—

The "civilized society" of this world did not seem to feel the same way.

In the locals' eyes, "Captain Duncan" was a world boss wandering around outside the main cities. The moment he appeared within sight, they had to pull together a twenty-five-man raid…

Duncan sighed. If there had been even a single book to read on the Vanished, he would not be this passive. His only source of information here was that muttering Goathead, and right now he did not dare reveal too much about himself in front of it.

Come to think of it… how could a ship this big not have a single book on board?

For people living at sea, a lonely, long voyage was an extreme kind of pressure. People needed some way to ease that stress. Ordinary sailors

might not have much time to read for fun, but the great “Captain Duncan”… surely wasn’t illiterate, right?

After all, being a captain was a skilled job that demanded a high level of knowledge. Even the roughest, most savage pirates needed a captain who could read an enchanted sea chart, understand the stars, and calculate the route.

With that doubt in mind, Duncan asked a casual question. He was careful, trying to make it sound like an offhand remark. Goathead, however, answered without any hesitation:

“Books? Reading at sea is a dangerous thing. The beings in the Abyssal Deep and in Subspace are always waiting for a gap to appear in a mortal mind. The only safe reading is those ‘classics’ published by the Holy See. Those are safe, but so dull it’s better to go scrub the deck instead… and you have never been interested in anything from the Holy See, have you, Captain?”

Duncan raised his eyebrows at once.

Since when did reading a book at sea become a life-or-death risk? And only the Holy See’s “classics” could be read safely? What kind of sickness did this endless ocean have?

He felt he had learned a bit more about this world, but with that came new questions. Duncan could only force those fresh doubts down inside. He walked to the rail and looked out over the endless stretch of sea and sky.

The golden “Sun” poured down rays of light, and what shone on the sea looked like rippling sheets of fine gold leaf. If he ignored how strange the Sun itself looked, it really was a beautiful scene.

“I want to hear your advice,” Duncan finally said to Goathead after much thought. His tone was still careful. “I’m getting tired of this aimless sailing.

Maybe…”

He had only gotten halfway through the sentence when a strange feeling suddenly rose from deep inside. It came from the link between him and the Vanished, as if some “foreign object” had suddenly touched the ship. Right after that, he heard a “thump” from the stern, like something heavy had hit the deck.

Duncan frowned. At once he drew the loaded flintlock pistol at his belt with one hand and his single-handed longsword with the other, then ran quickly toward the source of the sound.

Moments later, he reached the aft deck. The thing lying there quietly left him stunned.

It was that ornate wooden chest that looked like a spirit coffin.

It was that eerie doll.

A chill crawled over Duncan’s heart. He stared hard at the still-wet chest, half expecting it to pop open by itself at any second. Then he noticed that all the nails around the lid were gone.

Those were the nails he had hammered in before throwing the chest into the sea. They should have been very solid.

He stood there, facing the chest with tense caution for several minutes. At last he made up his mind. Keeping a tight grip on the flintlock in one hand, he slipped the longsword into the crack of the lid with the other, then pried it open with force.

The ornate lid creaked open. The lifeless Brother doll still lay quietly inside, surrounded by red velvet lining, like a princess in her sleep.

Duncan stared at the doll for several seconds and spoke in a deep, serious tone: “If you are alive, then get up and speak with me.” [He believed he was

showing enough authority in that moment.]

He repeated the words twice, but the doll did not move at all.

Duncan kept his serious expression as he looked at her, then finally said in a flat voice: “Very well. Then I can only send you back again.”

Once he finished speaking, he closed the lid again without hesitation. Then he fetched tools and hammered in another crisscrossing ring of coffin nails. When he was done, he even found an iron chain and used the hooks already on the chest to fasten the lid down tight.

After he finished all this, Duncan straightened up and clapped his hands in satisfaction. He looked at the “spirit coffin” he had bound up and nailed all over and nodded slightly. “This time you shouldn’t be able to climb out of your coffin.”

Then he kicked the chest into the sea again without a hint of hesitation.

He watched the chest hit the water, then watched it rise and fall with the current as it slowly drifted away. Duncan let out a small breath, then turned and left the stern.

But halfway across the deck, he suddenly turned back and looked again toward where the chest was drifting.

The wooden chest was still bobbing on the waves.

Duncan nodded, turned away, and kept walking. Then he suddenly looked back again.

The chest was still floating on the sea, and it had already drifted very, very far.

“Maybe I should put a cannonball or something in there. Then it would sink…”

Duncan muttered this under his breath, then finally turned for real and slowly walked toward the captain's cabin.

"You are a bit harsh toward that lady," Goathead's voice sounded in his mind.

"Shut up—are you really calling a cursed doll a 'lady'?"

"It does indeed look like a cursed doll… but what curse on the Boundless Sea could compare to the Vanished and the great Captain Duncan? Captain, that lady is actually quite gentle and harmless…"

Duncan: "…"

Why did Goathead sound so proud every time it mentioned the curse and ill fame of the Vanished and Captain Duncan?

Perhaps sensing Duncan's foul mood behind the silence, Goathead quickly changed the subject: "Captain, you said earlier that you wanted to hear my advice. Specifically…"

"We'll talk about it later. I need to rest for a while. Steering the Vanished through the Spirit Realm earlier drained my energy. Stay quiet for now."

"Yes, Captain."

Goathead fell silent, and Duncan returned to the captain's cabin. He walked to the chart table and let his gaze casually sweep over the enchanted sea chart.

The next second, his eyes suddenly froze.

The enchanted sea chart seemed to have changed in a subtle way. The gray-white patches that had covered the whole sheet and writhed like living things had faded a little. The sea area around the Vanished was becoming clear!

Was this thing… updating information on the surrounding waters in real time as the Vanished sailed?

Duncan stepped up to the chart table at once and focused all his attention on the subtle shifts on the enchanted sea chart.

But his concentrated state did not last long.

From deep within his mind, the Vanished once again sent the signal of “contact with a foreign object”. Right after that, Duncan heard another “thump” from the deck just behind and to the side of the captain’s cabin.

Chapter 10: Elegance Wasn’t Exactly Elegant

That “coffin” had come back again.

On the stern deck of the Vanished, Duncan stared without expression at the ornate wooden chest lying quietly in front of him. Beads of water slid from its edges and dripped at his feet, proving that his memory of throwing the chest into the sea was not false, proving that this thing had, until not long ago, really been drifting out on the ocean.

Such a strange sight was enough to chill anyone’s heart, yet for some reason Duncan felt calmer than he had expected.

Maybe it was because he stood on this already bizarre ghost ship. Maybe it was because he had just gone through a thrilling “Spirit Realm drift” and a collision. Or maybe it was because he had been dealing for days with the equally strange Goathead. Whatever the reason, Duncan seemed to have built up some immunity to the weird supernatural phenomena of this world.

In fact, when he threw this “cursed doll” into the sea last time, he had already faintly guessed that things would not end so simply.

He lowered his head and, as expected, saw that the iron nails and chain he had hammered around the “coffin” were gone without a trace. He bent down and once again used the pirate sword in his hand to pry open the lid.

The ornate gothic doll still lay quietly in the center of the red velvet lining, hands folded, calm and elegant.

But this time Duncan clearly noticed that the hem of her dress seemed damp from seawater. A faint fishy smell came from the inside of the lid.

So far, this strange doll had done nothing out of line or dangerous besides vanishing and then returning over and over. But the fact that it kept “going away and coming back” was already a standard trait of a cursed item.

Duncan watched the doll for a while, face blank, then broke the silence with a half-smile: “I suddenly feel like satisfying my curiosity…”

As soon as he spoke, he turned and walked toward the nearby hatch, quite at ease leaving the doll on the deck.

Although he was personally very wary of the doll and did not want her near him, his understanding of the Vanished and of Goathead told him that leaving her on the deck for a while would not cause any real trouble. Even if she suddenly lashed out, the many “living things” on this ship would be enough to handle it.

He was going to use this time to do some “prep work”.

Duncan crossed the stern deck, opened the wooden door leading below, and stepped onto the age-worn wooden stairs. Familiar with the path, he went down into the space beneath the deck. This counted as the “upper gun deck”, the place where the cannons were set.

Old-fashioned muzzle-loading cannons lay quietly along both sides. Moldy, darkened planks covered the gunports. Black powder barrels and solid iron-ball cannonballs were piled between the guns, as if they had been resting there for a century.

As Duncan’s gaze swept over these timeworn things, a thought suddenly struck him.

On this ship, he had never seen a second “human” figure besides himself. So… who operated these cannons?

Did they, like the Vanished itself, load and fire on their own when needed?

And what about the freshwater tanks on board? Did they refill themselves? What about damage to the hull? Did it repair itself? Or… did this ship even have a real concept of “damage”?

Questions bubbled up one after another in his mind, and he had no idea where to start answering them.

He knew very well that he still understood far too little about this ship. In the past few days, he had explored it to a certain extent, but only enough to get a rough idea of its upper structure. The deeper areas were far stranger and more intimidating than the upper levels.

On top of that, he had always pinned his hopes on leaving his “bachelor apartment” and returning to the normal world on Earth. He hadn’t focused his main effort on the Vanished at all, which left him with very little motivation to act “on this side”.

But now, he suddenly felt more curious about the ship—or rather… more of a sense that he should take control of it.

This was his ship. He ought to understand the Vanished.

Maybe this change had started the moment he took hold of the wheel.

Duncan shook his head, set his later exploration plans aside for now, and walked over to the pile of cannonballs.

A short while later, Duncan returned to the stern deck with several cast-iron cannonballs in his arms. Just as he had expected, the cursed doll in the “coffin” still lay honestly inside the chest.

“Did she move at all just now?”

“Not at all,” Goathead’s voice answered at once. It sounded like it had been holding itself back for far too long, and once it started talking the words

poured out. “This lady was as quiet as she looks. You should trust my judgment—she is mild and harmless to you. Since she has come back to the ship again and again, that may mean she and her spirit coffin have some kind of connection with the Vanished. A great gardener once said…”

“Shut up.”

“Oh.”

Duncan stared expressionlessly, his gaze fixed on the doll in the chest.

He didn’t know if she truly couldn’t move or if she was still pretending to sleep even now—but either way, he didn’t care.

He was going to satisfy his curiosity.

The solid cast-iron cannonballs were very heavy. When traitors were executed at sea, tying just one of these balls to a man was enough to send even the most seasoned sailor to the bottom.

Duncan put four cannonballs into the “coffin”—then went back to the gun deck and hauled up four more.

Eight cannonballs almost filled every bit of remaining space inside the chest. The elegant gothic doll was now surrounded by a ring of iron balls. She looked… very well-armed.

Elegant she was not; creepy she definitely was.

Duncan closed the lid of the “coffin” again, then, with quite a bit of effort, pushed the chest to the edge of the deck. Even with his current strength, it was not an easy job.

In the end, he lifted his leg and kicked the “coffin” into the sea.

A heavy splash rang out. The ornate wooden chest went straight into the water and sank.

Duncan stayed at the rail of the deck, silently using his gaze to stare at the spot where the chest had gone under. He did not move for a long time.

Goathead's voice sounded in his mind: "Captain, have you changed your mind? If you regret throwing away this piece of loot, the Vanished can try to fish the chest back up with the anchor. It's not the proper use for an anchor, but the anchor says it can try…"

"Shut up."

"But you've been standing at the rail for quite a while…"

"Shut up."

"Oh."

Duncan let out a quiet breath.

He absolutely could not admit that his toes hurt in front of his flunky Goathead.

So he stood there on the deck for several minutes with his toes throbbing, forcing himself to keep the stern look a dignified captain should have. By the end, he even started to wonder if he looked like one of those rocks on the shore that just stand there, waiting forever for a spouse to come back. Only when the pain finally faded did he turn, unhurried, and go back to the upper gun deck below.

He waited quietly for a few more minutes. When he felt that enough time had passed, Duncan suddenly walked toward the stern end of the gun deck. He opened the viewing window between the two stern guns and focused on the sea outside.

Goathead hadn't stayed quiet for long. It couldn't help itself now: "Captain, what are you…"

Still staring at the waves, Duncan answered without looking up: “I’m very curious how that cursed doll makes it back here.”

“Uh… because she’s a cursed doll?”

“…I really appreciate your habit of not overthinking things. But I believe that even for a cursed doll, there must be some kind of process when she returns to this ship. She wants to pretend she’s ‘dead’, yet she keeps coming back. I think there must be a reason behind that, and she must have the ability to communicate. But right now she refuses to talk. So I’ll have to figure out how she moves and force that thing into a conversation.”

Goathead was silent for two seconds, then asked cautiously: “Captain, you seem… suddenly in a better mood? Ah, that’s a wonderful sign! Ever since you woke up last time, you’ve been in low spirits and lost interest in many things. Your loyal First Mate and Second Mate and…”

“Shut up.”

“Oh.”

Once Goathead quieted down, Duncan kept watching the sea with full attention. In his line of sight, the water behind the stern remained calm.

The “coffin” really seemed to have sunk into the Deep Sea with no sign of coming back.

But with the experience of the last two times, Duncan was especially patient now. He silently counted the minutes, waited, and watched, letting the Time-Stream flow.

He did not even notice that he was actively hoping for the doll to appear again.

Then a tiny black shape entered his vision.

As the waves rose and fell, that shape suddenly rushed into view. It was the ornate wooden chest, bursting out of the sea like a lone boat in the storm. The beautiful gothic doll stood in the box, arms wrapped around the coffin lid, paddling for dear life in the waves with big, sweeping strokes.

A gothic doll standing inside her coffin, brandishing her own coffin lid as she rode the waves.

Elegant she was not; she was honestly creepier than eight cannonballs.

Duncan was deeply shaken.

Chapter 11: Alice

Duncan felt he would probably never forget this scene for the rest of his life.

On the eerie, dangerous Boundless Sea, an ornate spirit coffin rose and fell with the swells, while a gothic doll driven by some mysterious force stood inside it, clutching a huge coffin lid in both hands, riding the waves straight toward him…

And she didn’t look very happy about it.

No matter how he looked at it, the whole thing was far too creepy. For a moment, Duncan didn’t even know whether he should be more shocked that the cursed doll was actually moving, or more stunned by the way she swung that coffin lid around with such crushing momentum. All he knew was that this scene was nothing like what he had imagined.

He had pictured several ways she might return to the ship, but he had never once imagined… this.

While Duncan was still staring in a daze, the doll had already reached the stern of the Vanished.

Even though her “oar” was a coffin lid, her paddling speed was shockingly fast. She had a strange lightness and strength about her. Duncan carefully leaned his head out of the viewing window and saw the doll toss the coffin lid back into the spirit coffin. Then she reached out, grabbed a protruding timber at the stern, and began to climb up at incredible speed—agile and swift, as if invisible ropes were pulling her upward.

At the same time, the heavy wooden chest rose from the sea in a bizarre way, floating at her side as if it had lost all its weight.

Duncan quickly ducked his head back in before the doll noticed him.

The doll clearly had no idea that the captain of this ghost ship had been watching her in secret. In almost the blink of an eye, she climbed up the tall stern of the Vanished and flipped herself onto the deck.

She waved a finger in the air, and the spirit coffin that had been floating beside her drifted down and landed neatly at her feet. Then she turned her head this way and that, as if checking the deck to make sure no one was around. Once she was sure she was alone, she quickly smoothed out her slightly wet dress and started scrambling into the coffin, using both hands and feet.

Halfway in, a pirate sword suddenly thrust out from the side and blocked her. Right after that came the sharp click of a flintlock hammer being pulled back.

The doll froze at once. She tried to turn her head and saw a ghostly captain wreathed in green flames standing beside her, staring coldly at her with his gaze. His voice sounded like it rose from the depths of the Spirit Realm, cold as the Abyssal Deep: “Oh. I caught you, doll.”

In front of Duncan, the doll clearly trembled. She seemed terrified and tried to dodge to the side, but her panicked movement went wrong. Her upper body jerked, Duncan heard a clear “click” from the base of her neck—

And then her head fell off.

Right before Duncan’s eyes, a beautiful head dropped from the doll’s shoulders. Her long silver hair spread out in the sea breeze as the head rolled to his feet.

The doll's body stayed in its half-crouched pose beside the spirit coffin, ready to run. One hand groped blindly in the air, while the fallen head stared helplessly up at Duncan, mouth opening and closing: "Hel… help… help…"

It was no exaggeration to say that Duncan's heart almost stopped right then —though he wasn't even sure if he still had a heart after being burned by ghostly flames. Still, watching that head come off with his own eyes really shook him.

The roaring ghost flames around him hid the horror on his face, and his moment of stunned delay looked to the doll like cold indifference. Miss Doll never even noticed that this terrifying Captain Duncan was actually more nervous than she was. She just kept repeating: "Help… help… my head… fell off…"

Duncan finally snapped out of it. He patted the small heart that now only existed in his imagination and tried his best to control his movements and his voice. He calmly watched the doll for a while and confirmed that, for all her strange and uncanny traits, she seemed… more afraid of him, this "ghost captain", than he was of her.

Once this fact became clear in his mind, Duncan realized he had to keep up this calm front.

He still didn't understand this world, and he understood this cursed doll even less. Until he could fully control the situation, the identity of "terrifying Captain Duncan" was his biggest shield.

At the same time, he couldn't just leave the doll in front of him alone. The way things had turned out was not what he had expected, but the result was clear enough: this doll could communicate with him.

He holstered the flintlock and kept his other hand on his sword. At close range, a flintlock with only one shot was obviously less reliable than a blade, and his rushed practice with firearms was far from enough to make him a skilled gunman.

Then, with his free hand, he picked up the doll's head from the deck.

The feeling was very strange. Even though he knew she was only a cursed doll, the act of reaching down and grabbing a "head" still made Duncan uneasy.

The faint warmth coming from the head almost made him want to fling it away on reflex.

This was just too creepy and uncanny.

But in the end he held back that strange urge. He looked the head in the eyes and asked calmly: "Do you want me to put this back for you?"

"My… my… my…"

"Fine, you do it yourself," Duncan said, nodding as he passed the head to the doll's hand, which was still groping blindly in the air.

He watched as those hands caught their own head with practiced ease, fingers nimble. She casually smoothed her messy silver hair, adjusted the angle a little, and set the head back on her neck. A crisp click sounded as the ball joint locked perfectly into place.

The whole process flowed smooth as water. It was clear this was not her first time doing it.

Right after that, the doll's stiff face turned lively again. She blinked and let out a long breath: "Whew… I'm alive again."

Duncan: "…"

From any angle, he felt like he should say something about that. But then he remembered the persona of “Captain Duncan” and the fact that he still knew nothing about this doll’s background. So in the end he only nodded to her with a blank face and said: “Good. Now you’re coming with me—we need to talk. You’ve come onto my ship again and again.”

As he spoke, he let the ghostly flames around him fade away and returned to his original appearance.

Transforming into his spirit form was a power he had gained after taking the wheel of the Vanished. But he had only just come into contact with it and was far from skilled. He had no idea how to really “use” this power yet. Other than steering the ship, he didn’t even know what else it could do.

Just now, he had released it only to create a strong image in front of the weird cursed doll—and to build up his own courage.

Now that his image was set and the doll was very cooperative, there was no point in wasting more energy keeping the flames burning.

The cursed doll obediently stood up beside the coffin. Then she stared in shock as she watched Duncan return to human form. Her eyes went wide: “You… you’re not a ghost?”

Duncan gave her a calm glance: “When it’s necessary, I can be.”

The doll raised a hand to steady her head, and there seemed to be a hint of awe in her eyes.

Duncan had no idea what she was so in awe of, but it was obvious that her head still wasn’t very secure. She had probably almost scared it off again.

He turned and walked toward the captain’s cabin. Through his live link with the Vanished, he could feel the doll hesitate for one or two seconds, then follow after him honestly.

Just as he expected, the ornate and strange spirit coffin also floated close behind her. It seemed she had to take it wherever she went.

A short time later, Duncan led the cursed doll into the captain’s cabin.

Under the carved Goathead’s gloomy gaze, the ghost captain and the cursed doll sat facing each other across the chart table. Duncan sat in his heavy dark-backed chair, while the doll used the coffin-like chest as a seat, sitting on it with graceful poise.

She really was elegant and composed. When she sat quietly, silver hair hanging down, gothic dress spread around her as she perched on the chest, she looked like a work of art that should be displayed in a palace and guarded by soldiers.

Unfortunately, every time Duncan looked at her, he couldn’t help thinking of how this young lady had just been riding the waves on a coffin and then running around with her head falling off…

He sighed, then put his cold, stern expression back on and fixed his gaze on the doll’s eyes: “Name?”

“Alice.”

“Race?”

“Doll.”

“Occupation?”

“Doll… Why are you asking all this?”

Duncan thought for a moment and said: “To get some basic information.”

Chapter 12: The ghost captain and the cursed Doll

On the two sides of the wide chart table, Captain Duncan of the Vanished sat facing Alice, the doll who was under the curse.

The air between the two of them – though maybe neither of them was actually human – was not what you would call friendly.

The doll who called herself “Alice” still looked a little nervous. Even though the ghost captain in front of her had promised her temporary safety, in front of Duncan’s face that seemed to come with a natural +10 intimidation bonus, even a cursed doll like her clearly could not calm down.

She kept a dignified posture as she sat on her own coffin lid, but the fingers quietly pinching the hem of her skirt gave away her unease.

Duncan stayed silent for the moment, studying the “lady” in front of him while he thought.

A doll driven by some unknown power, clearly not made of flesh and blood, yet able to speak, walk, and even feel a bit warm to the touch – a “supernatural subject” like this, back in his hometown, would have made it onto Approaching Science, and it would have run for at least three and a half episodes.

Duncan did not know what kind of being a doll like Alice counted as in this world, but in the past few days of dealing with Goathead he had picked up some information in a roundabout way. He knew that even though this

world had “supernatural Visions”, such extraordinary things were not something you could see everywhere. And the doll in front of him…

Duncan guessed that even in this strange world full of Anomalies, she had to be some kind of special existence.

He had reasons for this guess. The mechanical ship that had collided head-on with the Vanished was very new and had a well-trained seafarer crew. He had seen with his own eyes that even when they fell into great terror, many sailors on that ship still held their posts. Inside that ship were many compartments and items whose use he could not make sense of. Many of them were covered in complex rune markings, and the style of those marks was very similar to the symbols carved on the surface of Alice’s spirit coffin.

In other words, the purpose of that advanced ship’s voyage was very likely to escort – or rather “guard and transport” – this cursed doll, Alice.

Duncan shifted his posture in the chair and fixed a calm yet serious gaze on Alice. There was no doubt that his ship now had a very remarkable “guest” on board.

But on the other hand, this doll did not really seem like a frightening figure. She actually seemed quite timid.

After all, right when they met, before he had even said much, she had gotten so scared that her own head had fallen off.

“Excuse me…”

Probably because Duncan’s long silence and gaze put too much pressure on her, Alice finally could not help speaking. “And…”

“Where did you come from?” Duncan finally withdrew that oppressive gaze and asked in a calmer tone.

Alice clearly froze for a moment, as if processing what he meant. After a few seconds, she lightly tapped the ornate wooden box under her. “From here.”

Duncan’s expression turned a bit stiff. “…”

“Of course I know you used to lie in that box,” he coughed twice and said. “But I’m asking where you came from – as in place, understand? Do you have a hometown? Or some kind of point of origin?”

Alice thought carefully again, then calmly shook her head. “I can’t remember.”

“You can’t remember?”

“How could a doll have a hometown?” Alice folded her hands on her lap and answered with dignified seriousness. “Most of my memories are of lying in the box. I lay in here, being carried from one place to another. Sometimes I could vaguely feel people walking outside the box or standing guard… Ah, and I remember some low whispers. The people watching outside my wooden box talked about things in voices full of fear and tension…”

Duncan raised his eyebrows. “Talked about things? What did they talk about around you?”

“Just some boring trivial stuff.”

“But I’m curious now,” Duncan said very seriously. He believed they might really have been trivial matters, but right now he needed to learn about this world in any way he could – even from the noisy idle talk of its ordinary people.

“…Fine. What I heard most often was a designation, Anomaly 099. They seemed to use it to refer to me and my box, but I don’t like it. I have a name,” Alice said as she thought. “Besides that, I sometimes heard them

talk about seals and the curse or something, but most of those memories are blurry. When I'm in the box I sleep. I don't listen very carefully to what's going on outside."

The doll spoke slowly, then suddenly seemed to remember something and added: "But I still remember what I heard most recently. That should have been right before I came to your ship. The voices talking outside the box kept mentioning a place, the city-state of Pland. That seemed to be their destination… and should have been mine too?"

"The city-state of Pland?" Duncan's eyes grew thoughtful as he silently noted that name in his heart.

He had finally learned something useful again, though he did not know when this bit of useful information would come in handy.

Then he looked up and fixed his gaze on the doll again. "Aside from that?"

"Aside from that, I mostly just slept, Captain," the doll said solemnly. "When people seal you inside a big box like a spirit coffin and there are endless drowsy whispers drilling into your ears around you, what else can you do but sleep? Do sit-ups in your coffin?"

Duncan's mouth twitched.

She looked dignified, and when her head was not falling off she was an elegant beauty. But in reality she not only paddled across the waves on her coffin lid, she also suddenly came out with snarky lines that could choke a person.

In his heart he quickly built a new picture of Miss Alice.

But on the surface he still kept up the image of the calm and stern Captain Duncan. He only made a noncommittal sound and then went on: "So, aside from being groggy in the wooden box, you know nothing about the world

outside. You can’t tell me how this world has changed now, and you can’t tell me where any harbor or city-state is located.”

“I’m afraid so, Captain,” the doll said seriously, then suddenly seemed to realize something. Her eyes widened a little and she stared nervously at Duncan. “So… are you planning to throw me off the ship again? Because I’m not worth anything?”

Before Duncan could answer, Alice went on: “Fine, I understand. It is your ship, after all. But this time, can you not stuff cannonballs into the box? Honestly… eight cannonballs was a bit much…”

It was clear that this doll was not in a good mood, but she did not quite dare to throw a fit.

Duncan also felt very awkward. The main reason was that, back when he had stuffed the cannonballs into the box, he had not considered that he would later have to calmly discuss the matter with the person involved. At that time he had treated the Alice lying inside the box as a standard cursed doll from a horror movie. All the scenes in his head had followed that style. He had never thought that this cursed doll had not crawled out of The Grudge at all, but was more like something that had walked out of a courtyard comedy instead.

So all the early preparations he had made to fight a terrifying curse now turned into sheer embarrassment.

Fortunately, Duncan had a thick skin, and that stern, gloomy face of his looked as if it had been carved there with an axe and a knife. As long as his nerves did not short out, he could keep a straight face. So he forced himself to ignore the embarrassment caused by those eight cannonballs and just shook his head lightly. “I haven’t decided yet whether to throw you off the ship. After all, you always seem to find a way back on board. I’m just curious – why do you keep coming back to the Vanished? I can see that

you’re actually wary of me, and of this ship. Since that’s the case, why not stay far away from this danger?”

“This ship is called the Vanished? Fine, I really am a little… afraid of you and your ship, but compared to that, isn’t the deep sea even more dangerous?”

The doll stared quietly at the ghost captain in front of her. In her sight, behind this tall man stretched endless dim nothingness. That darkness overlapped with the real scene in the cabin, as if two worlds had been forced together. Yet compared to those vast, suffocating shadowy voids, the things that came from the deeper parts of the Boundless Sea made someone like Anomaly 099 feel even more danger.

“In this world, is there anything more frightening than the Deep Sea?”

Chapter 13: Long-Term Bed Rest Is Bad for Your Neck

The Deep Sea was something worth fearing.

Alice was a doll, but her bright eyes could still show feelings, and her expressions changed in ways that could not be explained by common sense. So Duncan could clearly see in her face that fear and rejection toward the Deep Sea – or rather, toward certain “things” in the Deep Sea. When he linked this to the Spirit Realm and the so-called border manifestations he had seen earlier out at sea, it was easy to realize that the vast ocean he sailed on definitely hid a Great Terror.

Yet the Vanished sailed on this endless sea, and so did that mechanical ship he had collided with in the Spirit Realm before.

This could not help but make him curious about more distant things. What was the land of this world like? Or rather, did normal land even exist in this world?

However, the doll in front of him could not answer his questions. Most of the time in Alice’s memories she had been in a dazed state. In Duncan’s judgment, that had to be the effect of some kind of seal, or some kind of “suppression.”

He also remembered what he had seen of the inside of that mechanical ship when they passed each other, through the vast senses of the Vanished. Those esoteric runes, the arrangements full of religious symbols, and the signs carved on the outside of Alice’s spirit coffin all pointed to one thing:

This “cursed doll” was definitely deeply feared in “civilized society.”

Duncan gave the doll in front of him a meaningful look, and she met his gaze with calm, gentle eyes.

“Let me confirm again. You truly don’t remember where you came from, and you can’t recall what you’ve been through in the past, right?”

“I don’t remember,” Alice answered very earnestly. “Ever since I first had memories, I’ve been lying in this big box. I don’t know why, but it seems there was always a group of nervous people around me. They were afraid I would come out, so they sealed the box in all kinds of ways. To be honest, thinking back now, I suddenly feel that the ring of nails you hammered into my lid was actually pretty friendly… Even though you later added eight cannonballs, at least you didn’t pour lead into it, right?”

This time Duncan did not pay attention to Alice’s trash talk, but continued to ask: “Then where did your name come from? Who gave you this name? If you really never left the box and never had contact with anyone, why would you have a name? Did you give it to yourself?”

Alice suddenly froze.

She really did seem lost. She stayed in that blank state for more than ten seconds. Just when Duncan was starting to worry that this doll also came with a “crash” setting, the doll finally moved again. “I… don’t remember. I’ve known from the start that I’m called Alice, but I didn’t give myself this name, I…”

She muttered in confusion and unconsciously held her head with both hands. The sight made Duncan’s eye twitch, and he hurried to stop her. “All right, if you don’t remember, then forget it. You don’t have to yank your head off…”

Alice: “…”

After that, Duncan asked the doll many more questions, but sadly most of them led nowhere.

Just as the doll herself had said, for most of the time since she became aware, she had drifted in a daze in that spirit coffin, staying in a state that switched between sleep and half-awake. She knew very little about the outside world. The only knowledge she had came from snatches of talk she heard outside the spirit coffin while half dreaming. Those bits of trivia could hardly help Duncan piece together the outline of this world.

But even so, Duncan did not walk away empty-handed. In talking with Alice, he at least confirmed a few things.

There was a kind of power structure in this world called “city-states”. That word came up again and again in the doll’s story and made up almost all of her journey. The end of this particular journey had been a city-state called “Pland”.

It seemed to be a prosperous place. The sailors said in their talks that “it holds an important position on many routes”.

Second, Alice also had the designation “Anomaly 099”, and that seemed to be some sort of “official” label in the civilized world. As for the name “Alice” that she used for herself, so far it seemed that no third person knew it besides her and Duncan.

Finally, Alice had been transported from one city-state to another again and again. And she did not seem to be the only Anomaly moved in this way. On some trips she had heard the escorts mention “other sealed vaults” in their conversations.

From this, Duncan boldly guessed that this constant relocation of Anomalies might itself be a necessary method of sealing them and keeping them from “getting loose.”

And it was obvious that this time the team responsible for transporting Anomaly 099 had run into terrible luck. Because of the sudden appearance of the Vanished, the “doll” they were guarding had already escaped.

It was just not clear what was so terrifying about this strange cursed doll, or what kind of damage she would cause now that she was free.

After all… she looked quite harmless while staying on the Vanished.

To be honest, Duncan was rather disappointed.

He had thought he had finally found a channel that could help him understand this world, but he had not expected the one lying in the coffin to be as confused as he was.

But when his gaze swept again over Alice, still sitting quietly on the wooden box, this disappointment faded a little.

At least he now had another person to talk to on the Vanished – even if she seemed to be a doll, even if her head falling off was terrifying, even if she surely had more secrets, even if she sometimes blurted out trash talk.

But she was still a lot more normal in style than that noisy Goathead.

And speaking of weird dangers… of this Boundless Sea, this Vanished, and all the strange things on this ship, which one looked safe?

From an outsider’s view, it even seemed that this “Captain Duncan” was the most dangerous thing on the Boundless Sea.

Duncan let out a breath. Without noticing, his expression relaxed a little, and he asked in a casual, chatty tone: “I want to know – if I throw you off the ship again, what will you do?”

Alice blinked. “Will you stuff in cannonballs this time?”

“No.”

“Then will you nail it shut?”

“Uh… no.”

“Pour in lead?”

“No… Ahem. I mean, if I refuse to let you stay on the ship…”

“Then I’ll just paddle back again,” Alice said, sitting there with perfect poise and a calm face. “I don’t want to be swallowed by this sea. At least your ship gives me a place to stay.”

Duncan was shocked by how frank this doll was, to the point that for a moment he did not know whether to call her honest or thick-skinned. After thinking for a while, he finally managed: “You could be a bit more tactful…”

“You already know the answer anyway, don’t you?” Alice said with a smile. “But if I come back again, I might find some place in the cabin to hide so you won’t notice me. I won’t rush onto the deck in such a loud way again. I haven’t been awake for long. I didn’t think things through when I came back those last times, but now I have experience…”

Duncan cut her off. “My senses cover the whole ship. I can even tell where every wave hits the hull.”

The rest of Alice’s words were instantly stuck in her throat. “Ah…”

Duncan went on, still looking calm: “And I could also choose to destroy you outright, using a more thorough way to keep you from clinging to me and my Vanished.”

The doll seemed to have truly never considered that possibility. Her eyes widened on reflex, and then there was a click at her neck…

The now headless doll fumbled to catch her own head and started hastily pressing it back onto her neck. The mood Duncan had been trying to build

collapsed at once. He could only sigh with a helpless smile. Only after Alice put her head back on did he continue: “But I’ve suddenly decided that having one more crew member on this ship isn’t a bad thing. If you can behave yourself on this ship, I can give you a position.”

“You should have said that earlier! My head almost got scared off!”

In the end Duncan could not stop the corner of his eye from twitching. “So what is wrong with your neck anyway?”

Alice looked innocent. “I don’t know! I don’t usually get that many chances to ‘come out and move around’. How would I know why my body has this kind of problem…”

Duncan quietly looked at Alice for a few seconds, then said with a straight face: “Looks like long-term bed rest is bad for your neck.”

Alice: “…”

Looking at the speechless doll, Duncan suddenly felt a bit better.

“All right. In short, the Vanished has a new crew member now – come with me, I’ll arrange a place for you to rest.”

Chapter 14: The Harmless New Crew Member

The Vanished was large, startlingly large. As a ship driven by sails, its size in Duncan's eyes had almost gone beyond what was necessary.

Such a size meant larger holds, more cannons, a sturdier structure, and a more stable posture when facing wind and waves. All of this meant it was more than enough to face the harshest challenges of long voyages.

But at the moment, Duncan had no plans for any so-called long voyage. This oversized ghost ship only brought him a sense of loneliness. So if there could be one more "crew member" on board that he could talk to, it would be no bad thing at all.

In any case, this big ship had plenty of vacant "guest rooms".

Footsteps broke the silence in the corridor. Duncan led that gothic doll down the wooden stairs and came to the cabins on the lower level beneath the aft deck. This place lay directly under the captain's cabin. From the layout, it should count as the "upper-class quarters" on this big ship. Compared with the darker, gloomier areas farther below, where a faint eerie air lingered, this place at least seemed bright and tidy.

Duncan stopped in front of a crew cabin, then casually pushed open the half-closed wooden door.

Inside was a small single room with simple furnishings.

There were several such single cabins on the ship, but they had all been vacant for a long time. There was no trace that anyone had ever used them.

When he first explored the upper levels of the Vanished, Duncan had already noticed these empty rooms. He had not thought much of them at the time. But now that he personally held command of this ghost ship and knew the secret of its ability to sail on its own, a question had surfaced in his mind.

Since this ship did not need any crew members at all… then who were these crew cabins prepared for?

The single cabins in the upper deck were clearly prepared for officers such as the first mate, second mate, and boatswain. In the lower levels there were also crowded bunk rooms prepared for ordinary crew members. Besides that, the ship even had a dining hall and a game room meant for many people to use. Unlike the sails and ropes that needed no human hands to control them, the presence of these facilities themselves meant they had been prepared for “people”.

Yet this ship did not need any crew members.

Duncan frowned slightly. He had already realized that, at some point in its history, this ghost ship that now sailed alone on the sea… must have had a crew.

At least when this ship was first built, it had been designed with proper living quarters for seafarers.

So what had actually happened to make the ship end up like this? Where had the original crew gone? Had the real “Captain Duncan” always been the master of this vessel? And how much inside knowledge did that strange Goathead know?

“Captain?” a puzzled voice suddenly came from behind him.

Duncan’s thoughts were cut off at once, and he jumped. The next moment he realized that it was the voice of that doll girl—he had actually forgotten about Alice’s presence for a moment.

Over these past days, Duncan had grown used to being the only living person on this ship. He had also grown used to the chatter of that noisy Goathead. Now that an extra person, Alice, had suddenly appeared, he actually felt a little unaccustomed.

“My name is Duncan. You can call me Captain Duncan—of course, just calling me Captain is also up to you,” Duncan quickly adjusted his expression, then turned to look at the doll girl following behind him. “From now on this empty room is yours. Go in and take a look.”

“Ah, all right!” Alice nodded. She first craned her neck to peek over Duncan’s shoulder at the room, then turned around to grab the wooden box that had been floating behind her the whole time. She hoisted it up onto her shoulder and carefully carried it into the room.

The sight of the “coffin” that never left Alice’s side made the corner of Duncan’s mouth twitch. He watched the doll girl set the “coffin” carefully beside the bunk, then check the velvet lining inside with extra care before she finally began to look around at the furnishings. At last he could not help but speak: “Are you going to carry that box with you all the time?”

“Yes,” Alice answered as if it were only natural. “Otherwise where would I put it?”

“This box used to be your seal. I thought you would mind that,” Duncan frowned. “But it seems you can’t leave it now.”

“It was those people who sealed me, not the box’s fault,” Alice sat down on the box as she spoke and patted the lid. “Would you like to come in and sit for a while?”

Duncan shook his head. “No need. How do you feel about this room?”

“Ah, it’s very nice.” Alice looked quite happy. She looked around at the simple furnishings as if she were standing in a splendid palace. “Is that a wardrobe? I don’t have any clothes to change into, so I probably won’t use it… but having a cabinet is nice. Oh, and a table. I can put things on it in the future, though I don’t think I have anything to put on it… maybe I can use it for my head? It would be more convenient when I comb my hair…”

“So long as you are satisfied.” Watching a gothic doll sit on a coffin and plan out her life was a very strange sight, especially when that plan already included some very suspicious details. Even so, a faint smile slowly appeared on Duncan’s face. He stepped back half a pace, his expression returning to normal. “You can rest here for a while and get used to the environment.

“Other than the stairs going down, you can move freely on this level and on the deck above. The layout here is not complicated. You should be able to learn where everything is soon.

“I will be in the captain’s cabin. If you need anything, you can come find me there. If I am not inside, there is a talking Goathead on the chart table. He is my first mate.”

Alice had been listening and nodding along. When she heard the last two sentences, her eyes suddenly widened. “Goathead?! That black wooden carving?!”

“So you have already noticed it.”

“I did notice it… but you say it can talk?! And it is your first mate?” Alice’s face was full of amazement. “I thought it was just… that is unbelievable!”

“…You are a doll that can walk and talk,” Duncan looked at Alice with a straight face. “And you still think a talking Goathead is unbelievable?”

Alice froze for a second. She lowered her head and looked at her own hands, then muttered as if she had just realized something: “Ah… I suppose so?”

Duncan shook his head and turned to leave. “That’s it then. Rest here. Come find me if you need anything.”

Alice’s voice came from behind him: “All right, Captain.”

After leaving, Duncan did not go anywhere else. He went straight back to his own captain’s cabin and sat down beside the wide chart table. The wooden Goathead on the table immediately stirred and creaked as it turned its head toward Duncan.

“Ah! The Captain has returned! It seems you have settled that young lady in! You see, just as I said, she is a gentle and harmless young lady. She will not hinder your voyage in the least and can help keep you company so you do not feel bored. I see you have already decided to keep her on the ship. Are you planning to assign her any duties? The Vanished does not need many hands. The deck cleans the deck, the cannons polish the cannons, the water tanks tend to the water tanks… perhaps she could manage the galley? You never seemed very satisfied with the food on board… Ah, speaking of food, we should first replenish some provisions. The salted meat and hard cheese in the storeroom may be a little too old by now. Rough seafarers will not be picky about what they eat at sea, but the great Captain Duncan certainly-”

Duncan felt as if his brain were about to boil. In that moment he once again became certain of one thing: with this noisy Goathead around, he really did need a “normal person to talk to” like Alice!

“Quiet,” he snapped, glaring at the Goathead. Only after the latter fell silent did he go on: “You stayed very quiet while Alice was here. I thought you had finally learned how to hold your tongue.”

“One must not interrupt when the Captain is interviewing a new crew member. That is the rule at sea, even for your loyal first mate and second mate and boatswain and-”

Duncan did not wait for Goathead to finish. In fact, if he did not interrupt, this Goathead would never finish. “Keep an eye on that doll these next few days.”

“Ah… ah? Keep an eye on that young lady? You still do not trust her? Oh, oh, that is true. A necessary degree of caution is what a captain-”

“She has many secrets, and she did not tell them all. Perhaps it is because she truly does not know some of them. Or perhaps… she is hiding things on purpose,” Duncan said calmly. “Whatever the case, she is still a ‘cursed Doll’, and she bears the label ‘Anomaly 099’. On that ship before, they used layer after layer of seals to keep Alice from ever leaving that wooden box. Now the sealed doll is strolling about quite freely on my ship. I need to take a little time to make sure that Alice really is a harmless doll… at least harmless while she is on the Vanished.”

Chapter 15: Touching the Flame

After he took the helm with his own hands, Duncan truly held control over the Vanished. He could also sense any movement anywhere on the ship. Even so, out of caution, he still ordered Goathead to keep constant watch over the “cursed Doll”.

He knew he was no expert in the field of occult studies. He knew little about the supernatural forces of this world. A doll that could walk and talk was far beyond his knowledge. Alice’s behavior might be harmless, but if that doll girl had any effects that could not be seen with the naked eye, he would very likely fail to notice them.

In this respect, Goathead was more professional than he was.

Even putting that aside, Duncan knew he could not watch over the Vanished every moment. Although he had already decided to live on this side of the world, when necessary he would still have to return to the other world behind the door. At that time, he might not be able to sense anything happening on the Vanished.

When he thought of this last point, Duncan’s eyes changed slightly. Without a word, he glanced at Goathead on the edge of the chart table. The obsidian-carved eyes of the latter answered with a hollow gaze.

When he went back to the other side of the door, when he returned to his small single apartment… would this Goathead sense it? When he left the Vanished, what was the situation on the ship?

These questions that suddenly rose in his mind made Duncan feel somewhat restless. Under Goathead's hollow gaze, however, he did not show anything. Instead, he split off a bit of attention to check on Alice's situation.

Of course, he had no habit of peeping. That did not change even when the other party was a "non-human being". He only roughly sensed what was happening below the deck. Even with just the information passed through his link with the Vanished, he could at least tell where Alice was and whether she was trying to damage anything.

After all, beneath the harmless, elegant, and pretty exterior of that doll girl lay the essence of a cursed Doll, a dangerous individual that ordinary people in this world called "Anomaly 099".

She was still in her room. She really might just be examining the furnishings and setting up a place to rest.

Duncan let out a small breath. At the same time, Goathead suddenly spoke beside him: "Captain, what are your plans next? If you are feeling bored, your loyal-"

"Quiet." Duncan glanced at Goathead, then pressed both hands on the edge of the chart table. As his thoughts shifted, the feeling he had when his hands were on the helm rose up once more. The emerald flame once again flowed like water.

In the burning blaze, Duncan's body once more became a spirit form. The streaming fire spread out from the chart table, flowed out of the captain's cabin, up to the upper deck, climbed the masts and the rigging, and made the translucent Spirit-Sails on the masts billow in the wind.

As the many main sails, side sails, and jibs adjusted their angles nimbly in the sea breeze, the huge three-masted ship began to slowly pick up speed on the vast, boundless ocean. Duncan's gaze fell on the enchanted sea chart in

front of him. As he had expected, the grayish white mist that had been coiled over the enchanted sea chart changed at once. The silhouette that represented the Vanished started to move slowly forward, and the mist around the silhouette faded away along with it.

After a brief moment of thought, he tried to focus his attention on the enchanted sea chart. The faint emerald flame wrapped around the chart table, extending his will as the captain. In this subtle “connection”, Duncan finally became vaguely aware of the secret of this enchanted item.

With a thought, the silhouette on the enchanted sea chart that represented the Vanished suddenly grew a little larger, then at once shrank back to its original size.

Duncan was “zooming” the scene shown on the enchanted sea chart, and this fanciful attempt actually worked. For now, no matter how he zoomed in or out, the edges of the enchanted sea chart still showed nothing but fog. Yet Duncan was already sure that this chart could record every inch of ocean that the Vanished had explored. It could also present the details around the Vanished precisely and in real time!

Under Goathead’s hollow gaze, Duncan’s face did not change at all. He looked as cold and serious as a true captain calmly studying the enchanted sea chart. Even so, a faint excitement rose in his heart.

His eyes swept over the flames rising from his own body. His mind sensed the state of the Vanished and the changes in the enchanted sea chart.

This strange green fire really was the key to controlling the Vanished, and also the key to controlling many of the eerie objects on this ship.

Perhaps… this was the power of the Captain?

Duncan pondered this Power of Flame. He understood very well that, if he wanted to truly master this ship and survive in this strange world by taking

the ship as his foundation, he had to understand his own abilities.

First, he had to gain full control over this flame.

As for the “plans” Goathead had just asked about…

Duncan looked at the enchanted sea chart as it slowly changed in front of him, and at the mist slowly clearing around the silhouette of the Vanished. His intentions were very simple.

Since he knew too little about this world, since the whole map was still covered in fog, then revealing the map first could not be wrong.

After all, one set sail in order to roam the seas.

Anyway, in the minds of the people of this world, “Captain Duncan” was already a world boss that wandered the wild places everywhere. Even if he and the Vanished behaved and stayed at sea, that would not improve his reputation in the slightest.

As for whether there would be any danger in sailing aimlessly like this, Duncan had his own view: before he took the helm himself, this ship had already been drifting everywhere. The Vanished had never dropped anchor or moored anywhere, so where would any “extra risk” come from?

Compared with that former blind drifting, sailing with the sails up at least let him disperse the fog on the enchanted sea chart. This meant he was no longer completely passive and lost in the mist.

Duncan rose from behind the chart table. The green flames on his body slowly faded. Yet in his perception, the translucent Spirit-Sails on the Vanished’s masts did not vanish with them. Some of the green fire clinging to the masts and rigging still burned, continuing to carry out the captain’s will.

Combined with what he had observed the last time he held the helm, Duncan had a faint understanding in his heart.

Although the Spirit-Sails had only flared up in the blaze after he “took the helm”, neither the towering sails nor all the self-moving things on the ship actually relied on the captain’s own power. This ghost ship had its own source of power.

He still did not know what kind of “energy” made the ship move. But it was clear that all he needed to do as captain was to give the ship its orders.

Then the ship would faithfully carry out the captain’s commands.

Duncan stepped away from the chart table and turned his head to look at the small door at the very back of the captain’s cabin.

Behind that door was his private bedroom as captain. During his first few days exploring the ship, he had always used that room as his resting place.

Now he needed a quieter environment in order to study what else he could do as the captain of the Vanished.

Before that, however, someone still had to watch over this ship that was already in full sail.

He looked at the wooden Goathead on the edge of the chart table and spoke in a very matter-of-fact tone: “You take the helm.”

“Ah?” Goathead froze for a moment, sounding a little surprised. “But Captain, you-”

“I have things to do. Do not disturb me during this time.” Duncan seemed not to care about anything Goathead wanted to say. He simply gave his orders in a completely natural way. At the same time, in his other layer of awareness, through the information carried along the deck by the spreading

green fire, he could clearly see the many… connections hidden deep within the ship.

Masts, rigging, sails, rudder, cannons…

Everything was connected in the unseen. Some kind of “nerves” or “blood vessels” ran through the entire ship, and all of these connections ultimately converged in the captain’s cabin.

Goathead was faintly linked to all of it.

Perhaps this mysterious and eerie Goathead was the Vanished itself. Or perhaps it was some kind of “control mechanism” meant to take over the whole ship in an emergency.

Duncan was not the one who had built this ship, so naturally he did not know how it worked. Still, he thought that the real Captain Duncan must know what Goathead was capable of.

From another angle, since Goathead always called himself the “first mate”, it was only natural that he should be able to take the helm in the captain’s place when the situation required it.

Duncan had to take a small risk and do something he had never done before, but which a true captain had to know and would certainly do.

After all, a captain had to rest at some point.

One second later, Goathead let out a cheerful and noisy cry. “Ah, yes, Captain. You can focus on your work. Your loyal-”

Duncan paid him no attention. He only waved his hand casually, turned, walked into the bedroom at the back of the captain’s cabin, and shut the door behind him.

Chapter 16: Walking the Spirit Realm

The door closed behind him, shutting out Goathead's hollow gaze.

Yet Duncan could still clearly sense the Vanished and every small change on this ghost ship. In that shared perception that felt like an extra limb, he "saw" a series of sails on the Vanished finely adjusting their angles to the sea breeze, while the black wheel on the steering platform at the stern turned slightly, making the Vanished even steadier on the waves.

As he had expected, Goathead had temporarily taken over the helm and was carefully carrying out his duties as First Mate. But Duncan could still seize control of the ship himself at any time.

Compared with when he steered it directly, the Vanished was now a little slower and less nimble. But Duncan's main goal right now was to disperse more of the fog on the enchanted sea chart. He had no clear destination or route anyway, so he did not care about this small loss.

After he confirmed that Goathead showed no unusual movement and that the special Doll made by that Brother under the deck was also staying quietly in its room, Duncan let out a small breath and looked around the not very large cabin.

This was his private captain's cabin and also the most comfortable and refined room on the Vanished. Besides a soft bed, there was a classical wardrobe by the wall opposite the door and a shelf holding many strange monstrous curios. Across from the bed stood a dark brown desk, but there

were no books on it, only a few ornaments and tools for writing and drawing.

Beside the desk there was a window that looked straight out over the distant sea. On the wall next to the window hung several hooks. The pirate sword and flintlock pistol Duncan now carried had originally hung from those hooks.

Duncan walked to the desk, set the sword and pistol within easy reach, then opened a drawer and checked the powder and lead bullets stored in a wooden box.

A small brass spirit compass lay beside the bullets and powder bag. Duncan picked it up and saw that the needle under the glass cover still spun wildly, as if it was always dragged by an invisible field of chaos. A line of tiny words was engraved on the base of the spirit compass.

“We are all The Lost Ones.”

Duncan turned the spirit compass idly in his hand, watching the needle spin around like a drunk.

He had checked everything here many times. He had found this room during his first explorations, and the things inside, including that one line of words, were most likely left behind by the original Captain Duncan.

After he went over all the information he had in his mind, Duncan let out a breath, set the spirit compass back on the desk, and lifted his right hand to rub his fingertips together.

A tiny green flame lit at his fingertips. In its glow, half of Duncan’s hand turned transparent and unreal, almost like a spirit form. But under his conscious control, the flame did not spread everywhere as it had before. It stayed in place above his finger like the flame of a candle.

When the flame steadied, Duncan brought his other hand close to feel it. Then he took a quill from the side and touched the flame with the end of the pen.

He felt no heat. The quill did not catch fire. Only a faint green color spread along the shaft, making the pen glow with a ghostly light.

Duncan did not “feel” any feedback from the quill at all. That was completely different from when he had touched the enchanted sea chart and the helm with the flame.

Duncan quietly noted this new experience in his mind. This spirit form fire had no temperature and did not ignite things. It most likely only reacted to Anomaly objects on the Vanished and gave no feedback at all when it touched ordinary things.

Then what if it touched an Anomaly that came from outside the Vanished? Would the flame react?

Duncan thought about it. For a moment, the image of a certain Brother’s special Doll flashed in his mind. Alice seemed to be an Anomaly that came from outside the Vanished.

Would she be affected by this spirit form fire?

But he only thought about it for a moment, then pushed this wild idea aside.

Because even though Alice was not human and carried the curse as Anomaly 099, she was also an independent being who could walk and talk and had her own thoughts. Now she was also a crew member of the Vanished. Duncan had already started to treat her as a “person” without thinking about it.

He could not accept using a living person to test his flame. After all, he still was not sure what lasting effects it would have on an affected Anomaly, or whether it would be harmful.

After that, Duncan ran a few more tests. He studied the nature of the flame while also checking whether any of the items in the cabin had any hidden supernatural traits.

In the end, his gaze fell again on the small brass spirit compass with the message on it.

The brass spirit compass lay quietly on the desk, its needle spinning madly under the glass. Duncan kept the flame burning as he fixed a rather unfriendly stare on the needle, and for a moment he thought he saw it freeze.

Then it went right back to spinning in place as if nothing had happened.

Duncan: "…"

This thing had definitely reacted to his gaze just now!

He had been wary of this spirit compass from the beginning. It still bore the handwriting of the original Captain Duncan, and he worried that the dead ghost captain might have left some power or "trap" on this personal item to guard against thieves. Because of that, he had never tested the spirit compass with his flame. But after seeing it react, he suddenly made up his mind.

Duncan reached out and picked up the spirit compass. The cold touch flowed into his fingertips. After one glance at the still-spinning needle, he set the thing in his right hand, the one that held the spirit form fire, and slowly closed his fingers around it.

The pale green flame flowed at once like burning oil, seeping between his fingers. A layer of ghostly fire spread over the surface of the spirit compass. Countless phantoms rose and faded in the light. In the next instant, the wildly spinning needle jerked to a stop and pointed straight toward some place in the vast sea.

Duncan’s heart stirred. For one brief moment, he clearly felt the “feedback” coming from the spirit compass and confirmed that it was indeed an Anomaly that his spirit form fire could control. But before he could study the details of that feedback, a sudden “pull” slammed into him.

Duncan only felt his body sway. In the next second, his vision blurred. The furnishings of the captain’s cabin vanished without a trace. The walls and ceiling broke apart and dissolved like falling snow. In the drifting fragments of light and shadow, endless darkness filled his sight.

Stunned, Duncan stood at the center of the gloom, every alarm in his mind ringing. His first reaction was to reach for the pistol and sword that should have been at his side, but a moment later he found that only the brass spirit compass remained. He was still gripping it in his hand.

Duncan blinked. In his sight, countless fine threads of light suddenly spread out around the brass spirit compass.

These lines of light spread through the darkness, weaving together and stretching outward like a growing net. In the gaps where the light crossed, countless points of starlight appeared. Some floated alone. Some gathered into streams like rivers. Against the web of shining threads, they formed a brilliant starry river.

Duncan watched these visions in front of him in confusion. He was on guard and a little uneasy, but for some reason he did not feel any real sense of danger. In fact…

Among the dim web of light and scattered stars, he instead felt a long-lost sense of peace and comfort.

A moment later, a strange feeling came over him. Duncan’s eyes were drawn against his will to one cluster of starlight in the net. When he looked

at it, he felt that the light was shaking and about to fall, as if it would sink into the dark at any second.

He reached out toward that starlight without thinking.

At that moment, a huge force pulled at him. Duncan felt as if his very soul flew up. He rushed toward the starlight that was about to fall into the dark. The dense web woven by the spirit compass rushed backward in his vision, and the starry river around him suddenly began to twist and spin.

As he hurtled forward, he glanced down at his right hand that had been gripping the spirit compass, only to see that the compass had vanished at some point. At the same time, just before he touched the dim star of light, he caught a shadow forming in the darkness out of the corner of his eye.

The shadow appeared as naturally as if it had always been at his side and fell with him toward the dim point of light.

Duncan only vaguely saw that the shadow seemed to be a bird with its wings spread. Before he could make out any details, his vision went black.

Heavy sensations from the Mortal Realm world rushed into his limbs. With them came the stench of rotting flesh and the harsh sound of heavy chains scraping along the ground.

Chapter 17: The Cave

Cold. Damp. The stench of rotten meat. The scrape of chains against stone.

Many strange sensations flooded into Duncan’s mind, but for a time he could not manage to open his eyes. He felt as if his soul had been split in two. One part still stayed on the Vanished, while the other part had been stuffed into a completely unfamiliar body. This body was hard to control, like an old broken machine. A rush of mixed and chaotic sensations ran through its nervous system, wrapped in a dull and numb feeling. He tried to open his eyes and move his fingers, but he could not feel those parts of the body at all.

This awful feeling lasted for several seconds before the numbness and slowness in the nerves finally began to fade. Duncan felt his “body” waking from a long winter sleep and slowly regaining the ability to move.

He finally opened his eyes and saw what lay around him.

He saw a dim space that looked like an underground chamber. Torches burned on the distant stone walls, and their shaking light showed a terrible scene all around. Duncan saw many people, or rather, many dead bodies, thrown in a jumble on the wet muddy ground and rocks. Most wore ragged clothes. A few still had whole garments on their bodies.

Drops of water fell from the top of the cave. In the distance he could faintly hear the sound of dirty water flowing, like an underground river or a sewer. The sound of chains scraping seemed to come from the depths of a passageway that led off from the cave, and it was already fading.

Duncan blinked, trying to understand what had happened. He lowered his head and looked at his right hand. It was a thin, completely unfamiliar hand, with tattered sleeves around the arm. The brass spirit compass he had been holding the whole time was already gone.

He lifted his head and looked to his side. He still remembered that when he had moved through that starry web of light, he had seen a shadow following him. The outline of that shadow had looked like some kind of bird. But now, of course, he saw nothing.

That bird-like shadow seemed not to have come with him into this Mortal Realm space.

Duncan slowly flexed his hand, forcing down his nervousness. Then he tried rubbing his fingers together.

A very weak green flame rose from his fingertips.

To be honest, this little flame looked much weaker than what Duncan was used to, but it still made him feel a bit calmer. As the flame burned, his still-confused mind also steadied, and he felt more clearly a certain tearing and connection on the level of his spirit.

He clearly sensed that the other part of his spirit was not here. He sensed the Vanished, and sensed himself sitting at the desk there, with the brass spirit compass in his hand.

This feeling was very strange, but Duncan quickly began to understand what was happening.

His spirit had gone through some kind of projection, or extension. A part of his mind had crossed a distance he could not guess and had now slipped into another unfamiliar body.

And even in this projected state, he could still clearly feel the existence of his “real body”.

This had to be connected to the brass spirit compass. Was this the power of that Anomaly item?

Some guesses rose in Duncan's mind, but he did not let them run wild for long. After he confirmed that his real body was still safe and that his spirit was still under his control, only temporarily placed in this distant, nameless body, he calmed down a little and got ready to find out what was going on with this "new body".

First, he could be sure that this place was not on any ship.

This was land, the land he had drifted on the sea for so many days without finding!

Second, this gloomy cave clearly was not a good place. The bodies thrown all around did not look like any kind of proper burial. As for the body he now occupied… just what bad luck had trapped it in this mortal hell?

Duncan took a deep breath and pushed himself up to sit. This body had been leaning against a large rock the whole time, and the pose had not been comfortable at all.

But as he breathed in and sat up, a huge sense of wrongness rushed through the body. He felt the air he had drawn in spill right out again. A strange, empty feeling came from his chest, and even the motion of getting up felt twisted.

Startled, Duncan lowered his head and saw a big hole.

The hole gaped where the heart should have been. Everything that had once been there was, of course, gone. A chill wind blew through the opening, carrying with it the breath Duncan had just taken in and not yet let go. It drifted out into the damp air.

From a certain angle, Duncan could even clearly see the scene behind his own back.

“What the hell?!”

Even with nerves as tough as his, even after all the strange sights he had seen on the Vanished, Duncan still broke out in a cold sweat for a moment. Goosebumps rose on his skin in waves, and every hair on his body stood on end.

But right after that sharp shock, he realized that he was still standing here in one piece and even had the strength to curse.

Even with his heart gone and a huge hole in his chest, he did not feel any pain at all from this body.

“So this is… a corpse?”

A moment later, Duncan came to his senses. He understood his situation more fully and quickly calmed down.

Taking over a corpse and making it move might not be something worth too much fuss. After all, he already had a ghost ship that could sail on its own and a wooden goat First Mate who could nag a person until their brain boiled. Lately he had also met a cursed Doll who could split up and act alone and was good at riding the winds and waves on the Boundless Sea. Which of those things was not more shocking than “a dead man talking”?

At least he had only lost his heart. Alice’s head was often not on her neck at all…

With all these wild thoughts spinning in his mind, Duncan steadied himself faster than he would have believed. He checked how well this body could move and slowly got used to how the hole in his chest changed his motions. Then he stepped toward the bodies thrown around the cave.

“As I thought…”

Duncan looked at the first corpse and did not feel surprised at all when he saw the horrible hole in its chest.

It was a middle-aged man with a haggard face and ragged clothes, who looked like a beggar from the street. He had been dead for a long time, but his eyes were still wide open in anger, showing the struggle and despair of his last moment.

Duncan walked on and saw one corpse after another that had lost its heart. They lay miserably on the cold stone. Only two were different. Those two had terrible wounds on their heads, as if they had slammed into the rocks with great force and died on the spot.

Duncan could not help making a guess. Perhaps these two had killed themselves before they could suffer the pain of having their hearts cut out.

To be honest, what lay in this cave would be far too much for an ordinary person. Even Duncan felt it was hard to take after walking around and checking all the bodies. In the end he had to find a relatively clean rock a bit farther away and sit down. He slowly steadied himself and, as he cooled down, tried to work out the truth behind all this.

It was clear that this was a shocking mass murder. But from the cold, uniform way the victims had been killed, it seemed to be more than murder. It hinted at some kind of evil ritual.

Duncan called out the spirit form flame again and felt the link between himself and his real body. He knew he could cut off this “projected state” at any time and return to the safety of the Vanished.

But he felt that he had to find out what had happened here.

Even if it was only to gain some information about the land.

Duncan let out a breath and felt the wind leaking through his chest. He rose from the rock where he had been resting and looked toward the passage that

led deeper into the cave. He remembered that the sound of chains scraping had come from that direction.

There were not only bodies in this underground space. Other people were moving here as well. Those who could move freely in a place this horrible should be able to give him some answers.

Rushing in to check the situation would of course not be very safe, but Duncan did not care.

After all, his heart was wide open now.

Chapter 18: Sewer

Before leaving the cave where he had been hiding, Duncan first tore some rags from the nearby corpses and wrapped them around himself.

It was not because he could not stand the chill in the cave, but to cover his open chest a little. The hole in his chest did not affect Duncan's "life" at all, yet as someone who was a normal person at heart, walking around with a completely chilled chest felt a bit too strange. Putting something over it at least gave him some comfort and lessened the eerie feeling of the "draft" blowing through him.

Duncan also thought about the chance of suddenly running into other people in this underground space. By common sense, having a big hole in his chest would probably not help when talking with strangers…

So after this simple treatment of his "wound", Duncan carefully left the gloomy, damp cave. He stepped into a passage connected to the cave and slowly walked deeper inside.

This temporary body he occupied was not "convenient". The fatal damage in his chest did not only hurt his flexibility. Duncan could clearly feel how weak this body was. The arms and legs were so thin that even walking was slow. It was nothing like the body of the ghost captain, which was so strong it clearly went beyond that of a mortal.

Duncan could not see this whole body yet, but from the parts he could see, he guessed it belonged to a teenage boy. A boy whose body had grown weak from long-term, severe malnutrition. Even though a powerful ghost

captain’s soul was controlling this body now, the strength of the soul did not seem able to break the physical limits of such a frail vessel.

Sadly, he had no other choice now. Duncan could only control this barely usable body and slowly explore the deep passage. He knew that with this temporary body, he would be helpless in any real danger. All he could do was pray this shell would last a little longer.

The passage was deep, damp, and dark, but there seemed to be hidden vents. A faint airflow kept moving past nearby. Every so often, he saw torches or oil lamps hanging on the walls. Their presence proved that people still came here.

After following the passage for quite a long distance, Duncan suddenly saw the road ahead open up. Traces of human construction appeared in his view. At the end of the passage there was a fork. The passages connected to it had smooth walls and high half-round arches. The brick floor was black and wet. Along both sides, two channels flowed with nauseating sewage.

On the walls to both sides of the path, he could also see openings that looked like drain pipes. Sewage poured out from some of these outlets into the channels below and flowed toward an even darker distance.

“…A sewer?”

Duncan reacted quickly. What lay before him was clearly a rather large sewer system. The place that had held so many bodies earlier must have been a natural cave that happened to connect to this sewer.

A huge sewer, a natural cavern connected to it, and hidden corpses.

Countless guesses flashed through Duncan’s mind. While his thoughts spun, he carefully studied every detail of this “sewer”.

It was large in scale and finely built. The main supporting parts seemed to be made of reinforced concrete. If needed, it could probably even serve as

some kind of underground shelter.

To build something of this size, the city above the sewer had to be quite large. Its technology must also have reached a certain level.

Technology did not exist in isolation. Behind every piece of engineering there had to be countless related industries and techniques supporting it. Even a sewer could show Duncan the construction, planning, materials, and maintenance level behind it, as well as the residents' way of life.

This was enough for Duncan, who was now badly short on information, to gain some valuable knowledge about the civilized world.

Duncan walked along the sewer. After only a short distance, he suddenly stopped, and his gaze fell on a nearby wall.

A lamp was set into the wall. It had a glass shell, and outside it there was a metal cage that looked quite sturdy.

Compared with the torches and oil lamps he had seen in the cave, this wall lamp was clearly brighter. Inside the frosted glass, a bright flame burned steadily. Its light was enough to illuminate a long stretch of the sewer.

Duncan moved closer and examined it carefully. For him now, anything from outside the Vanished, especially creations of modern civilization, held great appeal.

After studying it for a while, Duncan finally understood what this light source was. It was a gas lamp.

But this gas lamp seemed a little different from the ones he had seen in books. Besides its shape, the most obvious difference was a few thin symbols on the glass cover.

The symbols seemed to have been added when the lamp was first made. They curved and twisted like pictographs. Duncan did not know these

symbols, but he was reminded at once of the mysterious runes he had seen on that mechanical ship and on Alice's "coffin".

Although the content was different, they had a similar… "feeling".

It was something sacred, something ritual.

Duncan stepped back a bit. He looked toward the deeper part of the sewer and saw a bright gas lamp burning every so often along the walls.

For an underground facility that almost no one visited except for necessary maintenance, the lighting here even felt a bit excessive. And on the shell of each gas lamp, there might be similar mysterious "runes".

This gave Duncan a feeling, as if these densely spaced gas lamps were actually fighting against something in this deserted underground darkness. As if the humans of the civilized world behind them were fighting against something.

Duncan walked along the path lit by the gas lamps. At the same time, his eyes watched the surrounding walls, floor, and arches for any useful clues. Suddenly, out of the corner of his eye, he noticed something odd.

He stopped between two gas lamps. This was one of the darker sections in the sewer. He looked up at a slant and saw that high on the wall, near the arch of the sewer, dark red paint had been used to draw something.

Duncan narrowed his eyes and tried hard to make it out. At last he saw what those rough lines formed. He saw many hands reaching up toward the sky, as if devoutly worshiping something. In the direction those hands crowded toward, a sphere hung high, shining with blazing light.

Under this picture of worship and crowding, there was a line of crooked writing. The strokes trembled, as if filled with intense fanaticism and expectation. The letters were not from any script on Earth, yet Duncan understood them naturally—

“The False Sun will fall in the end. The true Sun God will be reborn from blood and fire! All life returns to the Sun, all order returns to the Sun!”

Duncan stood silently in the sewer. He raised his head, staring at the dim border of the gas lamps’ light, staring at the dark red graffiti, staring at that blazing Sun that seemed soaked in blood and worshiped by crazed believers.

It was as if he had been staring at another world for a long time.

He stayed like this for a long while, until a burst of noise suddenly came from deeper in the sewer. Several footsteps reached Duncan’s ears.

He quickly turned his head toward the sound and saw a few robed, hooded figures walking over from ahead. Their heads and faces were hidden in the shadows of their hoods, like grim ghosts appearing in the filthy depths of the sewer.

Duncan did not hide. In fact, there was almost nowhere to hide in this straight stretch of sewer, and this clumsy, temporary body could not pull off any “blind-spot dodging” tricks. So after thinking it over for a moment, he simply stood in the middle of the sewer and calmly watched the very suspicious hooded figures walking toward him.

Since this body could not run and was doomed to be a one-use shell, he might as well trade it for a little more information before it was gone.

The next second, the hooded figures coming from the depths of the sewer noticed Duncan.

Chapter 19: Underground Assembly Hall

The robed, hooded figures naturally noticed Duncan, who stood in the middle of the path without dodging.

Duncan still looked the way he had when he first left the cave. His thin and dried-up body wore tattered clothes. The rags he had wrapped around his upper body hid the big hole in his chest. He stood in the middle of the path, looking as if he had been frightened still by the sudden appearance of these “hooded people”. The robed figures were clearly surprised too. They froze for a moment, and then the one in the lead suddenly shouted: “A sacrificial victim has escaped!”

Right after that, Duncan saw them running toward him. One of them shouted as he ran: “Hurry! Cut him off! Don’t let him get away!”

Duncan shrugged. He just kept watching these figures who, in every way, did not look like good people, running toward him while his face stayed blank. After weighing the situation, he had no intention of running at all. But the people on the other side still shouted as they charged: “Don’t let him run!” “A sacrificial victim has escaped!”

Duncan’s honest choice to stand there without moving actually made the whole scene awkward. The ones who were running and shouting clearly felt something was wrong halfway. Their cries stopped on their own, yet they still had to keep running toward him. Duncan could almost smell the mix of embarrassment and anger from under their dark hoods. Then these

embarrassed and angry people surrounded him from front, back, left, and right.

Only then did Duncan look around at the figures around him. After hesitating for a moment, he said: “Should I have tried to run just now? The mood seemed to call for it…”

The robed figures acted as if they had not heard Duncan’s dry joke. They only gave him a wary, cautious glance, then turned to look in the direction behind Duncan. Two of them ducked their heads and whispered to each other. Duncan faintly heard what they said:

“Why is there one out here?”

“Did those hounds from the Church find this hideout… but he doesn’t look like someone they let out…”

“We’ll take him back first. There is something wrong with this escaped sacrificial victim… we have to deal with him quickly.”

“Let the Envoy decide.”

Duncan had no idea who these people were, and he did not know what this “Envoy” they mentioned was. But thinking of what he had seen along the way and the word “sacrificial victim” they used, he already had a rough guess about some of the truth here.

He did not know how a “normal sacrificial victim” was supposed to react, and he had no wish to cooperate in their little “play”. He was outside the Vanished now, and using only a temporary body, so he had very little to worry about. After briefly looking around, he simply asked: “Where are you taking me?”

The robed figures were clearly surprised that this “sacrificial victim” spoke so calmly. Even though black veils on their hoods hid their faces completely, Duncan could still guess their expressions. One black-robed

man glared at the “sacrificial victim” through his veil and lowered his voice: “You have no right to ask questions — take him.”

Several black-robed men stepped forward at once, but before they could lay hands on him, Duncan took a step on his own and said: “No need to drag me. I’ll go with you.”

The black-robed men looked at each other. They probably thought this “sacrificial victim” was not right in the head. The leader only waved his hand and said: “Even better. You can’t escape anyway… come with us, and you might at least greet glory in a decent way.”

The black-robed men closed in around Duncan, blocking every “escape route” in front and behind, and led him deeper into the sewer.

The foul and dirty smell in the sewer was enough to make anyone sick, but the black-robed men seemed not to notice it at all. They walked calmly along the moldy, filthy path. Duncan followed them in silence, his face blank, while he pricked up his ears to listen to their talk. The black robes did not speak much, but in a few short exchanges, Duncan still heard some useful words, like “Pland”, “governor”, and “Church”.

“This is the city-state of Pland?” Duncan suddenly asked, as calmly as if he were chatting with old friends.

“Obviously…” one of the black-robed men answered without thinking, then suddenly realized something and gave Duncan a startled look. “You’re quite calm, kid. Do you know what’s going to happen next?”

“I can roughly guess,” Duncan said with a nod, even showing a small smile. Then he tested them with another question: “The true Sun God… right?”

The black-robed men clearly paused for a moment. They seemed to get the wrong idea from Duncan’s strange reaction. One of them whispered to his companion: “Wait, could he also be a believer of the Lord?”

“Impossible. He’s clearly an escaped sacrificial victim…” another black robe whispered, then glanced at Duncan. “You are clever, but don’t think that will spare you from the sacrificial rite… Our Lord has already judged your fate. You had better accept it gladly.”

Duncan did not comment. He knew his overly calm reaction had made these suspected cultists imagine the wrong story. They probably thought he was just pretending to be calm and acting as a “believer” to try to live. But only Duncan knew the truth.

This temporary body had trouble even moving normally. The muscles on his face were stiff, as if the nerves at the edges had died… of course all that was left was a calm, blank expression.

He did not care what these cultists thought. He only wanted to gather as much information as possible during this “one-time expedition”. So he casually asked: “You think the ‘Sun’ in the sky now is the False Sun? You think it will fall one day?”

“The false Sun will certainly fall in the end!” This was clearly a topic that could excite these cultists. Duncan got exactly the heated reaction he had hoped for from one of them: “Even those dogs of the Holy See have to admit in the history books that the Sun in the sky only appeared after the Great Annihilation, as a twisted and bizarre thing! The one that truly brought life and order to all things in this world was the Sun God. But our Lord’s divine authority was stolen by that vile impostor… That vile impostor will fall from the sky sooner or later!”

Then Duncan heard the cultists around him all join in: “The False Sun will fall sooner or later!” “The true Sun God will soon awaken!” “The extra seawater in this world will be driven back into the void of deep space by the Sun God’s power. The land will return to an age of plenty and stability!”

As he listened to these cultists, who were clearly getting carried away, Duncan's thoughts spun rapidly. He knew fanatics like these could not be judged by common sense, and what they believed was mostly twisted and altered information. But some of what they let slip was still worth noting—

The "Sun" hanging in the sky was a fake…

The true Sun had had its divine authority stolen…

They believed the true Sun was a fallen deity, and they believed this deity would "rise again from blood and fire"…

They had also spoken of the extra seawater in the world, and of an age of plenty and stability… What did those words mean?

Duncan's mind was full of thoughts, and the cultists soon calmed down again. They still remembered their task, and that they were escorting an escaped "sacrificial victim". The ones closest to Duncan fell back into silence, while the two walking at the very back muttered softly:

"Don't you think this 'sacrificial victim' is a bit strange?"

"Something is off about him… I feel uneasy."

"Maybe when he ran earlier, he stayed too long in the lightless underground, and something down there messed with his mind…"

"All the better. The Lord's power will purify him."

Duncan listened to the talk behind him. He paid special attention to the phrase "lightless underground". Just as he hoped to get more information from their chatter, the black-robed leader stopped walking.

"We are here."

The cultist in the black robe spoke in a low, cold voice.

Duncan felt a hint of regret, but then the sight in front of him took all his attention.

Ahead was the end of this stretch of tunnel, the place where several sewers met. In this wide space, like a small underground hall, there was an assembly of black-robed cultists!

Chapter 20: sacrificial rite

This sewer system was huge. In Duncan’s eyes, it already went far beyond what a city needed just to drain waste. The runed gas lamps everywhere and the reinforced structures that were sturdy enough to act as shelters made him guess a lot about what this underground facility was really built for.

No matter what the builders had in mind at the beginning, one fact was obvious: in the depths of this vast structure, hidden from the eyes of the surface world, this dark, cold place had become a nursery for some kind of evil power.

A Cult that claimed to worship the Sun in name, yet only made people feel a chill.

At the junction of several sewer corridors was a wide underground space. Solid concrete pillars held up a brick-built dome. Metal pipes crossed and joined around the dome like a web. Bright gas lamps lit the whole place and also lit up the crowd that had gathered in this “meeting point”.

At a glance, there were at least hundreds of black-robed figures squeezed into this foul, damp place. In the middle of them was a raised platform. A tall figure in a black robe stood on it. That was clearly the person of highest status among them.

The person on the platform did not wear a hood like the others. Instead, he wore a golden mask. The mask’s design was strange, like a disk that sent endless rays of light spraying outward, but its surface was also covered in many broken cracks.

Behind the masked man stood a strange totem on the platform—a tall wooden pole. A blazing fireball was fixed to the top. The core of that fireball seemed to be some kind of metal. Its surface was full of small holes, and the flames spurted out from those holes.

This was the scene Duncan saw when he was “escorted” here.

The black-robed people gathered in the hall noticed him as well.

“On the way here to the assembly site, we caught a runaway sacrificial victim!” One of the black-robed men who had been escorting him stepped forward and spoke respectfully to the “Leader” on the platform, his tone clearly eager for praise. “This sacrificial victim stayed in the dark for too long. His mind is already a little confused. Please show your power and let our Lord’s glory descend upon this pitiful body!”

The Cult leader on the platform, wearing the Golden Mask, turned around. He stared closely at Duncan’s blank face. His voice held a trace of surprise and coldness: “A runaway sacrificial victim?”

Duncan did not react at all. He only looked around this place with curiosity, including the Golden Sun Mask on the Cult leader’s face and the blazing fireball totem behind him.

Maybe these symbols were strange and eerie to ordinary people in this world. But Duncan saw it almost at a glance. These things were imitating the Sun.

They were not imitating the glowing orb in the sky now, the one bound by torrents of fire and two layers of rune rings. They were imitating the Sun Duncan knew, the Sun that shone with ten thousand rays of light and burned fiercely.

These people really worshipped the Sun. They worshipped a Sun that seemed to have “fallen” in some ancient age, and they worshipped it as a

kind of God.

Duncan raised his head. His expression was calm as he used his gaze on the black-robed priest looking down at him from the platform. But maybe because the muscles of this body's face had rotted, that calm look only made him seem even more like some dull, mindless thing in the priest's eyes.

The priest in the Golden Mask stared at Duncan for less than two seconds. Then he turned his head and ordered a person standing beside the platform: "Go check the place where the sacrificial victims are kept. Be quick and report back."

After giving that order, he nodded to the black-robed men who had "escorted" the sacrificial victim back. There was a hint of praise in his tone. "You did well. Even if this is only a tiny merit in our Lord's eyes, when sunlight shines upon all things again, it will become your eternal glory."

It was only a bland, routine compliment, but the black-robed men acted like they had been greatly encouraged. They became excited, praising the "true Sun God" as they pushed Duncan to the front of the platform. Only then did the masked priest finally speak to Duncan: "Poor one who walked onto the wrong path… have you felt the deep cold among lightless rock and mud?"

Duncan did not understand what this charlatan was talking about at all, so he stayed silent. The priest clearly did not care whether this "sacrificial victim" could respond. His words were not really meant for Duncan. They were for the congregation around them, and for the "Sun God" he believed in:

"Cold and darkness are the suffering left to this world by the false Sun. Under the false Sun's rule, the dark ocean of the Abyssal Deep ravages the world. Only scattered, broken pieces of land let living beings cling to life. Yet even on these broken lands, mortals can hardly escape suffering. Old

Shadows coil below the ground. In lightless tunnels they writhe, with claws that feed on man. Above the ground, hatred and conflict fill the world. Humans' pure souls are stained by the breath exhaled by the Eldritch God…

"How can we endure this long suffering? How can we endure the twisted and absurd world brought by the false Sun?

"We cannot endure it. We only wish for our Lord to return. We only wish for the true Sun God to descend upon the earth again, to burn in blood and fire, and to bring order and prosperity back to the Mortal Realm!"

Under the masked priest's passionate and stirring tone, Duncan could clearly feel the atmosphere in the hall change. The black-robed congregation grew more and more excited. At first they only echoed him. Soon those echoes turned into fervent shouts:

"We only wish for the true Sun God to descend upon the earth again! To burn in blood and fire!"

"We only wish for the true Sun God to descend upon the earth again! To burn in blood and fire!"

"May the true Sun God descend upon the earth again," the priest on the platform cried. Then he pointed at Duncan. "And today, our Lord will wake further from His sleep—the blood of the lost shall soothe the wounds left after the Sun's shattering!

"Bring the sacrificial victim up!"

Several black-robed men rushed over from the side, but Duncan moved even faster. He did not wait for anyone to push him and simply climbed up onto the altar by himself.

This body did not work very well, but climbing a platform was still easy enough.

Once he climbed up, he stood right in front of the masked priest. The priest was still frozen in the dignified and mysterious pose he had held when he gave the order just now. The change came so suddenly and so far outside his past experience that the head of the Cult did not react in time. He and Duncan stared at each other through the Golden Sun Mask, and the area around the altar suddenly fell into a strange silence.

Duncan seemed not to notice the change in the air at all. He only felt he had collected more information about this world, and he was very eager to see if, before this temporary body “broke down”, he could witness a few more rare scenes.

“So, uh,” Duncan rubbed his hands together with a kind of curious expectation and asked seriously, “and then? What do we do next?”

The masked priest: “…”

“Did you not hear me?” Duncan frowned—but because the muscles on his face did not work well, the frown did not really show. “I said, what’s the next step?”

Only then did the priest finally react. Even through the mask Duncan saw a flash of confusion in his eyes, but it vanished quickly. The priest pressed down his voice and said, “The Shadows in the dark truly did affect your mind. But don’t worry. The highest and holiest Sun will end your suffering… bring the sacrificial victim before the totem!”

Two black-robed men walked onto the platform at once. They grabbed Duncan’s arms and dragged him toward the Solar Totem Pole with the fireball on top. Duncan had no idea what came next, so he could not “cooperate ahead of time”, but he still did not resist. He stood obediently under the blazing fireball, held in place by the two black robes.

Even though Duncan did not struggle at all, the two black-robed men still used all their strength to grip the sacrificial victim's arms, as if they were afraid he might break free and resist at the very last moment. Their strength was an anomaly. Duncan could feel the bones of this temporary body slowly cracking apart. He looked at the two black-robed men with real surprise.

Right after that, the masked priest walked closer.

Duncan's attention went straight to him. He saw the priest pull out a strangely shaped dagger from his robe. The dagger was crooked and twisted like dried finger joints. Its blade was pitch-black, like it was carved from obsidian, and its surface reflected the firelight of the totem, making it look especially eerie.

Duncan quietly got ready to cut his Soul Projection. He knew this temporary body had almost collected all the information it could.

The Cult priest's benediction rang out over the altar:

"O highest and holiest Sun God! Please accept this sacrificial rite upon the high platform! I offer You this sacrificial victim's heart. May You return from blood and fire!"

Duncan immediately stopped his action of cutting the Soul Projection and stared at the Cult priest in front of him like he was an idiot.

Chapter 21: Good News, the ritual Went Very Smoothly

After hearing the words of that benediction from the Cult priest, Duncan at once stopped cutting his Soul Projection and returning to the Vanished.

He stared at the masked priest in front of him like he was an idiot. He stared at the little obsidian dagger in the man's hand, raised high in the air. He looked at the congregation around the altar as they all grew excited again and chanted the name of their "Lord", chanting the name of that "true Sun God" that legend said had fallen long ago and shattered into pieces.

They wanted to offer him, this "sacrificial victim", to the Sun God. The method was to offer up the sacrificial victim's heart.

Now Duncan finally understood where the horror back in that cavern had come from. He understood what kind of mad and evil acts these cultists had been committing.

Then he saw the masked priest take a step toward him, and a layer of pitch-black flame suddenly rose on the surface of the obsidian dagger in the man's hand.

This striking supernatural phenomenon instantly made Duncan curious. He guessed that the dagger might be some kind of "anomaly" item. He guessed that the priest might be a "special human" who could wield extraordinary power. He wondered how many such special humans there were in the civilized world, and what role they might play in society.

At the same time, he watched blankly as the little knife wrapped in black fire stabbed down, plunged into his chest, and cut through several layers of ragged cloth with a dull, hollow sound.

The flames burned a few times inside and did not burn anything at all.

On the Solar Totem Pole behind him, the blazing fireball suddenly gave off a series of unsettling cracks and pops. Mixed into those pops seemed to be some tearing, dizzying noise. Duncan vaguely felt that something had spread out from the fireball. It was a kind of cold and insane “touch”. He could not describe it well, not only because this temporary body had dull senses, but also because this feeling was beyond any experience he had ever known.

He only knew one thing: in a world where extraordinary phenomena truly existed, this priest’s sacrificial rite ritual had clearly gone very, very wrong.

The sudden change of the “Sun symbol” on the Solar Totem Pole at once drew the attention of the nearest congregation. With a few suppressed cries, the hall quickly fell quiet again after its earlier frenzy. Even the two black-robed men gripping Duncan’s arms seemed cowed by something. In panic, they let go and knelt toward the Solar Totem Pole in terror.

The priest holding the obsidian dagger stood frozen in place. He still held the blade, but stared fixedly at the “sacrificial victim” in front of him. Through the openings in the mask, Duncan saw a pair of eyes full of confusion and chaos.

Duncan tugged at his stiff lips and finally squeezed out a twisted smile. He slowly raised his right hand and laid it on the priest’s hand that clutched the obsidian dagger. Threads of green flame flowed out like water, seeping and winding around the dagger.

In almost an instant, Duncan felt “feedback” coming from the dagger. But strangely, that feedback felt weak and hollow, as if the dagger was only some cheap imitation. It was like an empty shell that held just a little bit of “borrowed power” inside.

Still, whether the dagger was fake or not did not matter much to him.

He smiled at the priest and said calmly, “I have to say two things.”

The next second, the priest felt his connection to the obsidian dagger suddenly get disrupted by some outside force. His fervent, burning faith in the Sun smashed into something like an unshakable wall and was cut off at once.

“First, I am a broad-minded person—look, my chest is this broad.”

Duncan ripped aside the already ragged cloth on his chest, which had been cut again by the dagger. A shocking hole appeared. Through that horrifying hole, the priest who was presiding over the sacrificial rite ritual could see clearly the scene behind Duncan.

“Second, try not to offer expired food to your Lord.”

Duncan gently pushed the priest’s hand away. For some reason, after he wrapped the obsidian dagger in the green flames of his spirit form, the priest seemed to lose most of his strength. Even with Duncan’s frail and weak limbs, he could easily shove this tall, burly priest aside.

Only after being shoved did the priest seem to finally snap out of it. Huge terror and anger washed over him. His muscles trembled as he raised his hand to point at Duncan. He tried to restore order on the altar with a furious shout: “Filth of true resurrection! This is a resurrected Restless Soul! You have defiled this sacred sacrificial rite ritual! Filth… which reckless Necromancer stands behind you?! Are you not afraid of the power of the Sun?!”

“I have no idea what you’re talking about.” Duncan glanced at the obsidian dagger in his hand. As he felt the faint power inside it, he spoke casually. Then he looked up at the priest again and listened to the crackling noise from the Solar Totem Pole behind him. A bold, strange idea suddenly popped into his mind. “But I suddenly want to satisfy my curiosity.”

He raised the obsidian dagger high. In full view of the still-panicked and terrified black-robed believers around him, he pointed at the masked priest and shouted:

“O highest and holiest Sun God! Please accept this sacrificial rite upon the high platform! I offer You this sacrificial victim’s heart. May You return from blood and fire!”

The next second, he saw the flames on the obsidian dagger suddenly surge higher. The icy presence spilling from the Solar Totem Pole behind him instantly gathered and focused, aiming at the masked priest not far away.

Duncan saw raw terror appear in the priest’s eyes. The man clearly wanted to leave the altar at once, but the dagger was faster than he was.

The dagger flew out of Duncan’s hand. It was pulled by some invisible force, wrapped in roaring black fire and faintly twining green flame. It shot straight into the priest’s chest. With a single, shrill scream, the Cult leader’s chest was pierced through, and his heart turned to ash in an instant.

A moment later, the dagger returned to Duncan’s hand. In that single trip out and back, the last trace of power within it seemed to be completely drained.

Given: inside the range of the Cult altar’s sacrificial rite, there were two people. One had a heart. One did not. Some Eldritch God insisted on having a human heart to taste today. Question—who would lose their heart?

Of course, it had to be the one who still had a heart.

Even if the logic made sense, the smoothness of the whole thing still went beyond Duncan's expectations. He had not thought that his wild little "experiment" would actually work. Only after the Cult priest fell to the ground did Duncan finally turn his head and glance at the now-calm totem behind him. His tone turned odd as he muttered, "So as long as the words are right, it doesn't matter who says them?"

The fireball on the Solar Totem Pole did not answer his question, of course. But the cultists around the altar had clearly reacted by now. Panic spread, as expected, but along with it, the fury of the most fanatical believers burst out. This anger even overshadowed the fear they had felt earlier when the totem showed its Visions.

The cultists closest to the altar reacted first. They charged at Duncan while shouting the Sun God's name. These boldest believers quickly drove more people to move. A large mass of black-robed figures rushed forward like they had lost their minds. Some even pulled short swords and daggers from under their robes.

Duncan had actually been planning to shout, "I offer the hearts of everyone on this altar to the Sun God" and test the appetite of this strange Eldritch God. But when he saw that some of the charging cultists had even pulled out revolvers from their robes, he dropped that idea at once.

Taking into account the time it took for the sacrificial rite ritual to take effect and the rule that "within seven steps a gun is both accurate and fast", he simply gave the cultists the middle finger and cut off his Soul Projection.

Let this mob of madmen keep on being mad. He was going back to the Vanished.

At the same time, on the vast Boundless Sea, a steady pattern of footsteps sounded on the deck of the Vanished.

A doll named Alice, wearing a gorgeous Brother long gown, walked out of her room and came to the door of the captain’s cabin.

This time, the ornate wooden chest did not follow behind Miss Doll. She had left it inside her room.

The captain had said that she could move as she wished in the cabins under the deck, and that she could also walk on the deck. If there was anything she did not understand, she could come straight to the captain’s cabin to find him.

Alice remembered all of that very clearly.

Julian, grandson of the Zhengde Emperor of the Grand Ming Empire and the own son of Empress Kang Ning, glanced at his proud and self-satisfied eldest Brother, his second Brother who understood how to weigh gains and losses, and his birth mother whose expression he could not read at all…

[Hmm, it really seemed like none of this had anything to do with him?]

So the young man calmly accepted the title of “Shame of Transmigrators” and began a lazy salted-fish life of eating and waiting to die.

Until a bowl of chicken soup arrived.

“Ahahaha! Chicken soup is here!”

Chapter 22: Crew Member Code

Alice stopped at the door of the captain's cabin.

The doll raised her head, looked at the dark oak door in front of her, and noticed a line of words on the doorframe, written in elegant cursive letters: "Door of The Lost Ones."

It was not strange at all for such a line of words to appear on the doorframe of the captain's cabin of the Vanished, but Alice still frowned without thinking. She was not curious about the door, but about why she could even recognize "writing".

She had no memory of learning letters. In fact, she had no memory of any "learning" at all. She did not remember ever gaining experience of moving about outside or talking with people. Yet this knowledge simply existed in her mind by itself.

She could read the letters on the captain's doorframe. She also understood what the different pieces of furniture in a room were used for. It was impossible to learn such things just by lying in a wooden crate and listening to people talk outside—so where had this knowledge come from?

Before today, Alice had never thought about this question. But for some reason, after talking with that "Captain Duncan", a strange thing rose up in the doll's mind, which was supposed to run calmly forever: the idea of "curiosity".

She thought back carefully. The change seemed to have started after Duncan asked about the origin of the name "Alice"… In that moment, she

began to question some of the things in her mind that had always felt natural. She tried to recall where her name came from, and then something in her mind loosened.

Alice did not know if this loosening was good or bad, but she did not like the feeling of confusion. So she soon shook her head and pushed the doubt aside. She steadied herself at the captain's door, then placed her hand on the oak doorknob and pushed forward gently.

The door did not move at all.

Alice froze for a moment and tried pushing again, but the wooden door felt as if it were cast from solid steel and did not budge.

Right as she wanted to try again, a voice suddenly came from inside the captain's cabin—a hoarse, low voice, as if it came from a rotting piece of wood: "The door opens outward, lady."

This was not Captain Duncan's voice. Alice jumped in fright, but she reacted quickly. She let out a hurried "oh" and pulled the door outward. This time, the door opened very easily.

Only then did she remember that when the captain had brought her here before, he had indeed pulled the door open outward.

It seemed that the "everyday knowledge" that had appeared in her mind out of nowhere was still only knowledge. After sleeping in a wooden crate for so many years, she still lacked real experience of living. Alice reflected on this a little, then carefully stuck her head in and looked into the captain's cabin.

The captain's cabin was empty. The striking chart table sat quietly under the lamp. A thin mist floated over the surface of the enchanted sea chart on the table, and the dark wooden carving of Goathead was turning its gaze from

the edge of the table. A pair of eyes carved from obsidian stared at her in a hollow way.

Goathead spoke, more polite than Alice had imagined, and said: “Please come in, lady. The captain is busy. You can wait for him here. Also, try not to stick your head in like that. It will make some overly nervous fellows on the Vanished think that someone hates them. It is very troublesome to calm them down—and if your head falls off again, that would be a problem too. I have no hands, so I cannot help you pick it up…”

It really talked! This wooden carving really talked!

Even though Captain Duncan had said before that the Goathead on the chart table could talk, it still stunned Alice to suddenly hear a wooden carving rattle off so many words at her. She took a moment to react, then answered: “Ah, okay. But my head actually does not come off that easily, and when they installed it last time, I even… Wait, you said there are some nervous ones on the Vanished… does that mean there are others on this ship…”

Only after that did Alice slowly realize what Goathead’s words had hinted at. She looked around in surprise and nervousness. For a moment, she felt that this captain’s cabin, and even every single thing on the Vanished, was swaying in the dim light and turning into “strange objects” like that eerie Goathead. Goathead’s voice then came into her ears again: “Is that so strange? It takes many hands to keep such a huge ship running. Did you think the great Captain Duncan would personally scrub the deck?”

What Goathead said actually made some sense. Alice’s mind, which had only just awakened and was not very quick yet, still felt that something was wrong, but after thinking for a long time she could only nod: “That is true… so there are many like you on the Vanished…”

“There is only one loyal Deputy to the captain. The rest are a bunch of dim-witted fellows. You do not need to think about talking with them—they

have no interest in talking with people anyway," Goathead cut her off before Alice finished. "But since you are the ship's new recruit, it is normal that you do not understand many rules and principles. As Captain Duncan's most loyal First Mate and Second Mate and… I need to tell you some basic knowledge that you must know to live on this ship. After all, the captain would never lower himself to explain such things to a new recruit… lady, are you ready?"

Alice listened in a daze. She had already forgotten why she had come to the captain's cabin in the first place. She only felt that every time this Goathead opened his mouth, a long string of words came pouring out. After a few exchanges, the pace of the conversation was completely out of her control. When he suddenly threw out that long chain of titles, her whole head buzzed. When he finally finished speaking, she could only nod without thinking: "Ah, ah, o-okay… okay?"

"Very good. Then next come a few rules that every crew member of the Vanished must know. They will help a new recruit adapt faster and fully receive the protection of the Vanished and the great Captain Duncan while sailing on the dangerous Boundless Sea…"

Goathead was clearly very pleased with Alice's answer. He spoke while shaking his wooden head, and his tone was full of pride—

"First, Captain Duncan is the absolute master of the Vanished. Captain Duncan is always right. Even if the Mortal Realm comes into conflict with Captain Duncan's words, you must still take Captain Duncan's judgment as the standard.

"Second, any crew member may only move in the areas that Captain Duncan allows. You must not take even half a step into any area that Captain Duncan has not ordered open, because those areas do not exist.

“Third, if you step into an unpermitted area and somehow still stay alive for a time, you must stay where you are and wait for Captain Duncan to bring you back, or calmly wait for death. You must never return on your own, because what you return to will not be the Vanished.

“Fourth, the Vanished always sails on the correct course. Never question the captain’s sailing plan. If you find that the scenery around the Vanished is different from what you expected, or if you find that the Vanished has entered a ‘deeper’ sea area, then this is a normal part of the sailing plan.

“Fifth, the captain will sometimes leave the ship, but he will always return. While the captain is away, the Vanished will continue to sail normally, but all crew members are strictly forbidden to go near the steering platform at the stern. The rudder system feels insecure when the captain is gone, and the ropes at the stern will strangle any rash fool who shows a ‘usurping’ attitude.

“Sixth, on the Vanished there are, and will only ever be, six basic rules for crew members.

“Seventh, the door of the captain’s cabin opens outward.”

Goathead seemed to have explained this “common knowledge” to new crew members many times before. He spoke of these rules very smoothly and naturally. But when Alice heard the last two, she immediately heard something wrong: “Wait, Mr. Goathead, in the sixth rule you said…”

“Sixth, on the Vanished there are, and will only ever be, six basic rules for crew members,” Goathead answered at once. When he talked about these basic rules, he never hesitated.

For a moment, Alice was not sure whether something was wrong with herself or with this “First Mate” in front of her: “But you just mentioned a seventh rule…”

“Seventh, the door of the captain’s cabin opens outward,” Goathead answered very naturally.

Alice stared blankly at the dark Goathead carving on the table. After doubting her ears, she started to doubt her own brain—but then she soon remembered that she did not have a brain. So she checked again: “These two… are not in conflict?”

“There is no conflict at all.”

Listening to Goathead’s firm answer and looking at his hollow, pitch-black eyes, Alice opened her mouth, but then suddenly swallowed all her questions.

Chapter 23: Bird

Alice did not understand many things in this world.

But at least, she had heard countless low whispers while inside the wooden crate, talks filled with fear and tension. From the mouths of those crew members and wardens whose nerves were extra tight because they were in charge of escorting Anomaly objects, she had built up the most basic understanding of certain “unusual matters”.

If something clearly went against common sense but still truly existed, then the first thing to do was to follow the existing safety rules. Only after keeping a safe distance should one think about study and analysis. That was the way to stay alive.

Alice actually did not feel much about the fact that she was “Anomaly 099”. She did not know what she could do, or what she had done, that made humans fear and guard against her like that. She did not know how an intelligent “Anomaly” was supposed to think to be “normal”—at this moment, she was simply thinking like a person.

Since Goathead said that the crew member rules had, and would only ever have, six items, then there were six. Since Goathead had mentioned a seventh rule, then she would also remember that seventh one.

But she still could not hold back some questions: “When I tried to push the captain’s door just now, it really did open outward—that is such a natural thing. Why do you have to stress it in the rules?”

The wooden Goathead quietly stared into Alice’s eyes. After a full two seconds, he spoke, more brief than ever before: “Sometimes, it can open inward.”

“Then…”

“If you see the door open inward, you must never go in. On the entire Vanished, only the captain has the right to do that.”

This was the first time since they started talking that Goathead had spoken in such a serious, even slightly threatening, tone. He had not been this serious even when he was explaining the crew member rules.

Alice was startled by his extra solemn tone.

Then right after that, Goathead’s tone turned light again. He spoke cheerfully, as if the serious topic had never happened: “All right, the necessary introduction process for a new crew member has ended. Now let us talk about something else… Ah, right, lady, did you come to the captain’s cabin for something? If you do not know how to use some facility on the ship, there is no need at all to bother the great Captain Duncan. If you just want someone to chat with, then you have come to the right place. I am very good at finding topics and I know countless great deeds related to this ship… Not interested in great deeds? Then I can introduce you to the most famous dishes on the Boundless Sea. I know a thing or two about cooking…”

Once Goathead started talking, he immediately got into the mood. Alice tried several times to interrupt but never found a chance, and by the time she realized that things were going very wrong, it was already too late.

Anomaly 099, the doll Miss Alice, today faced the second Great Terror on the Vanished, other than Captain Duncan.

At the same time, in the cabin on the other side of the wall, Duncan was quietly listening to the sounds coming from the enchanted sea chart room.

He had just woken up. His soul had returned to the Vanished from a distant body. He had not heard the start of Goathead and Alice's talk, but he had heard those "crew member rules" and the part about the "captain's door opening outward".

It was important information, an unexpected gain.

Duncan had not yet finished digesting the information he had just gathered from those cultists when he unexpectedly heard the conversation between Goathead and Alice. Both the strange and eerie "crew member rules" and the information hinted at by Goathead at the end were extremely important to him.

As expected, Goathead had known when he pushed the captain's cabin door inward to return to the "other side". For Duncan himself, that action was simply going back to his small apartment. But for this side, the Vanished, it seemed to mean that "the captain had temporarily left".

Goathead had no doubt about this at all and saw it as something Captain Duncan would naturally do.

So… had the "real Captain Duncan" of this ship also pushed open the door of the captain's cabin in the past and gone to some mysterious "world"? And had this not only happened once, but many times, so that it became something completely normal in Goathead's eyes and even became part of the Vanished's crew member rules?

This news was a good thing for Duncan. It meant that he would not need to worry too much when he went back to the "other side" in the future. Even if more new crew members joined the ship, he could openly disappear in front

of everyone by using this method, and he would not have to worry that anyone would copy him, follow, and discover his “secret”.

But on the other hand, Duncan also could not help thinking more. This was related to the “six plus one” crew member rules that Goathead had purposely brought up.

What did these crew member rules really mean? On what were these rules based, rules that sounded bizarre, dangerous, and even self-contradictory? Some parts sounded as if they existed only to stress the captain’s authority, but that clearly was not the whole truth. Those strict limits on behavior were more like a way to let the people on the ship live in some danger-filled environment, a way for the crew members to avoid invisible dangers by following fixed rules.

Duncan frowned slightly. He was thinking about his true place within these rules. Judging from the content of the rules, he, the “captain”, seemed to be the only one who held the greatest freedom and control. He did not need to fear the “invisible risks” on the ship. He was even the one who decided the range of many risks. But… all of this assumed that he was the “real Captain Duncan”.

That was the part most worth worrying about.

But then he suddenly remembered his recent exploration on the Vanished, and how he had walked around the cabins as he pleased.

Goathead had never reminded him about the crew member rules and treated him as the real Captain Duncan. While he moved about on the ship, he had never run into any “eerie danger”, and there could not be a second “captain” jumping out to give him any limits on where he could go.

From this point of view, the dangers mentioned in the “crew member rules” by Goathead did seem to be things he did not really need to care about.

Duncan let out a light breath and continued to listen carefully to the sounds from the enchanted sea chart room.

Half a minute later, he hated that he had no way to turn off his ears.

A trash-talking doll and the noisy Goathead started to talk with each other, and the latter clearly held an overwhelming advantage. His clattering nonsense rolled through the enchanted sea chart room like the waves on the Boundless Sea, and even Duncan, who was hiding in the cabin and secretly listening, could hardly bear it.

He felt that he should hurry out and rescue that poor doll, Miss Alice. With her lack of social experience, Alice was clearly no match for Goathead. But after a slight hesitation, Duncan still stopped.

He had just finished a strange “soul journey”. He still had much information to sort and even more experience to sum up. He had to figure out what exactly had happened to him just now and whether this process was under his control. From what he had seen so far, this ability to project his mind to a distant place would be his best tool for gathering information on land in the future.

Under normal conditions, he would also have to worry that staying in his room too long to study his new ability might draw Goathead’s needless attention. But now Alice was outside to pull that noisy thing’s attention away… which could not be better.

He silently said sorry to the doll, Miss Alice, in his heart, then lowered his head to look at his right hand. The next second, his expression froze.

The brass spirit compass, a bit larger than a pocket watch, had vanished at some point.

Yet he clearly remembered that until just a short while ago, he had been gripping that spirit compass tightly in his hand!

Duncan’s eyes suddenly grew sharp when he realized that he had not noticed the change in his hand at all. This kind of slack and carelessness had never happened since he came to this strange and eerie ghost ship.

In the next second, he closed his right hand slightly. A dim emerald flame quietly appeared between his fingers. Then he stood up from behind the desk, ready to use the link between this spirit form flame and supernatural objects to check whether there were any Anomaly traces in the cabin.

But just as he straightened up, Duncan’s movements suddenly stopped. Some subtle connection rose from deep within him. He looked, without thinking, toward the direction of that link, and in the corner of his eye he saw a few feathers, half real and half illusory, drifting down from the air.

Duncan looked in surprise to where the feathers were falling and saw a patch of phantom light quickly appear and gather in front of him. In just two or three seconds, the phantom formed into a snow-white…

Pigeon.

The missing spirit compass hung on that pigeon’s chest, and a familiar Obsidian Dagger lay quietly at the pigeon’s feet.

Chapter 24: Pigeons?

The snow-white pigeon stood blankly on the desk. The brass spirit compass Duncan had been searching for hung around its neck, and the familiar Obsidian Dagger lay by its feet.

Duncan stared at the pigeon in a daze, and the pigeon stared back at him in the same way.

It was not easy to read a bird's face, but somehow Duncan felt he could see this one's expression. Not only that, he even seemed to see a kind of "wisdom" shining in its slightly red eyes. Those two little bean-like eyes just stared straight ahead. When Duncan looked over, one eye clearly turned its attention to him, but the other eye still seemed to be watching the ceiling of the captain's cabin, its gaze wandering all over.

After several seconds, Duncan finally twitched the corner of his mouth and muttered without thinking: "A… pigeon?"

Why was it a pigeon? Why did a pigeon suddenly appear? Why was his brass spirit compass hanging on this pigeon? How did that dagger get here?

In short, all his questions boiled down to one thing: on this abnormal ship, was it even possible for anything normal to happen?!

While Duncan's mind was full of question marks, the dazed pigeon finally seemed to "wake up". It bobbed its head and took two steps on the desk, leaned toward Duncan, stretched its neck as far as it could, and let out a loud: "Coo!"

“…” Duncan looked at the bird without a word. For some reason, many classic images of pirate captains from his memories suddenly floated up in his mind. Then he lowered his head to glance at his own captain’s uniform and murmured: “A captain with a bird at his side was kind of standard, but normally it should be a parrot… what was with a pigeon?”

After hearing Duncan’s words, the pigeon immediately nodded very seriously and spoke in a stiff, oddly pitched female voice: “teleportation complete!”

All the muttering in Duncan’s heart and at the tip of his tongue was cut off at once. He almost choked on his own saliva. He stared wide-eyed at the White Dove in front of him, utterly stunned.

He remembered how he had felt when he first stepped onto this ship and, in the captain’s cabin, saw the talking Goathead for the first time.

But at least this was no longer his first day on the Vanished. He was already used to the Anomalies of this world. So the pigeon talking only surprised him for a moment. The next second, his face grew serious. Green spirit form fire rose in his palm as he watched the pigeon with gaze, staying on guard: “Where did you come from?”

The pigeon tilted its head. One eye stared straight at Duncan, while the other drifted toward the ceiling: “Address error. Please check the address again, or contact the system Administrator.”

Duncan: “…?”

His face froze for a second, but the wave in his heart was even bigger.

What the pigeon said did not match the “style” of this world at all. These were not words Goathead, Alice, or any of those black-robed cultists would ever use. Instead, they were terms far more familiar to him as Zhou Ming, a man from Earth.

Yet the pigeon seemed not to notice the change in Duncan's eyes and expression. It only lowered its head to peck at its own wings, then shook the brass spirit compass on its chest and began to stroll lazily around on the desk.

After a few steps, it ran over to the Obsidian Dagger. It used its claws to nudge the dagger a few times toward Duncan and spoke again in that strange, stiff female voice: "Pick up the Solar Axe and embrace the glory of battle!"

Duncan suddenly stood up from the desk. His chair scraped harshly against the floor. He stared hard at the pigeon, which still looked innocent and calm, while a feeling that was both absurd and eerie filled his mind.

This pigeon could not possibly be something that had always been on the Vanished. It was almost certainly not something that had always existed in this world.

Only Zhou Ming could understand the phrases it spoke!

Perhaps the noise from the chair hitting the floor was too loud, loud enough to reach the enchanted sea chart room. Duncan suddenly heard Goathead's voice in his mind: "Captain? Are you alright?"

Duncan still stared at the pigeon on the desk. He knew Goathead did not dare to peek into the captain's cabin directly, so he answered in his usual calm, low voice: "I'm fine."

"Miss Alice came to see you. Should I…"

"You entertain her for now."

"Yes, Captain."

Duncan let out a breath and glanced at the door that led to the enchanted sea chart room.

Goathead’s noisy attack on Alice was still going on. The doll had already tried several times to get up and leave, only to be stopped every time. Duncan felt he should probably go out and rescue that poor doll, but right now… he had something more important to confirm.

For now, Alice would have to suffer a little longer.

Duncan sat back down at the desk, ready to see if he could talk with the pigeon in a normal way. Only then did he notice something he had missed before.

A faint line of fire stretched out from the spirit form flame jumping between the fingers of his right hand. The thin stream of flame was as fine as a hair. It extended a dozen centimeters into the air before fading away.

On the strange pigeon, a wisp of ghostly emerald flame also twined around it, hidden in the gaps under its wings. That flame also stretched out into the air and vanished halfway.

Duncan frowned and lifted his right hand. With a thought, the flame leaped. The pigeon on the desk vanished at once.

The next second, the pigeon appeared on his shoulder. It lowered its head, pecked at his hair, and let out a loud: “Coo!”

Duncan snapped his fingers again, and the pigeon on his shoulder reappeared on the desk.

The brass spirit compass hung on the pigeon’s chest. Its shiny shell reflected the green light of the fire.

Duncan frowned. “…Is it connected to this brass spirit compass?”

He could already tell that the pigeon had a certain bond with him, a connection even closer than the one between him and the Vanished. This might also explain why the pigeon “knew” some things that only he knew,

strange bits of “knowledge” from Earth. He just could not be sure why the pigeon had appeared.

After thinking it over, he could only place his doubts on the strange brass spirit compass.

From his first tests with the spirit form fire until now, every Anomaly had started from this compass. The experience of soul traversal, the time he used mental projection to control a corpse, the compass vanishing just now and then reappearing on the pigeon’s chest… all of it seemed to begin with this thing.

Duncan watched the pigeon for a moment, then reached out toward the spirit compass.

He wanted to take it off and study it carefully.

The pigeon neither dodged nor tried to stop him. Yet Duncan’s fingers never touched the surface of the brass spirit compass. His fingers passed right through it and pressed into the soft fluff of the pigeon’s chest.

It was like passing through an illusion.

The pigeon hopped in place twice, as if Duncan had tickled it. It opened its beak and squawked: “It’s KFC Crazy Thursday today, send me 50…”

The corner of Duncan’s eye twitched. He tested it twice more, refusing to give up, and finally had to admit that he simply could not take the brass spirit compass off the pigeon. It had clearly undergone some kind of change and turned into an illusion bound to the pigeon. He could neither remove it nor touch it.

Or maybe… the pigeon was now the real body of the brass spirit compass.

A flood of wild guesses rose in Duncan’s mind, and even he did not know how many of them he should believe. The only thing he could be sure of

was this: the pigeon’s appearance was closely tied to his use of the brass spirit compass for soul traversal, and that experience might also have changed the form of the compass itself.

This might be the true nature of the brass spirit compass, its innate property as an Anomaly, or some kind of “price” for using it. As for why the pigeon was so strange… that was not because of the spirit compass, but because of Zhou Ming, the man from Earth.

He could not prove or disprove any of this yet, unless he found a manual for the various Anomalies on the Vanished.

For now, he at least had to decide what to do with this Anomalous pigeon.

After a short moment of thought, he decided to give the pigeon a name first.

“I have to give you a name,” he said seriously to the pigeon, tapping his finger lightly on the desk. “I think you can understand what I’m saying, right?”

The pigeon tilted its head. Its two bean-like eyes drifted as it looked at Duncan: “AI?”

Chapter 25: Communication Was Hard

The pigeon kept its head tilted, as if it felt Duncan had not heard clearly. Very soon it repeated itself, even louder: “AI!”

Duncan finally understood what the bird meant. “You mean your name is AI?”

The pigeon nodded proudly and paced back and forth on the desk. “Coo!”

Duncan rubbed his brow. He felt that talking with this bird was even stranger than talking with Goathead, mostly because of the pigeon’s odd, slippery way of speaking. “Do you know how you were born? Or… how you appeared here?”

The pigeon thought for a moment. Its two eyes drifted and stared in different directions at the same time. “Ah, the page is gone. Try refreshing it?”

Duncan: “…”

He found that he could not understand what was going on in this bird’s head at all. He could not even be sure if the strange lines it suddenly blurted out had anything to do with the topic.

But he was certain of one thing: the bird was thinking. It was seriously trying to talk with him.

It just clearly had its own idea of what “communication” meant.

Duncan spoke with the pigeon that called itself “AI” a little longer. Their talk always stayed like two parallel lines. They each said their own things. If he said it was related, he could not see where the lines met. If he said it was unrelated, the pigeon answered every question… and sometimes even gave a line or two that actually seemed to fit his questions.

In the end, the talk did not lead very far. Duncan could only frown and mutter, “What kind of cursed thing are you this time…”

He felt it would take a very long time to build normal communication with this bird. That process might even be harder than getting used to Goathead’s endless chatter.

The pigeon squatted on the desk across from him, blinking its small eyes innocently and, from time to time, muttering that he should send her 50.

Duncan ignored the bird’s murmurs. He rubbed his fingers together, watching the green flame of spirit form jump at his fingertips. At least he could be sure of one thing: even though the brass spirit compass had merged with the pigeon in front of him, at its core it was still an Anomalous item that he could control.

Ghostly green spirit form fire rose up. At almost the same time, emerald flame rose between AI’s feathers. The brass spirit compass hanging on her chest sprang open with a snap. Under the clear glass cover, the faint pointer slowly steadied under Duncan’s will, and the dial full of strange symbols was gradually filled with flame.

AI did not react at all. She simply bathed in the spirit form fire as if it were the most natural thing in the world, as though she were waiting for Duncan’s order.

Before the brass spirit compass was fully activated, Duncan took the initiative to disperse the flame.

In the process, Duncan also summed things up silently in his heart:

[The spirit compass still worked… it just had a strange “medium” added to it. For now he could not tell what role this pigeon would play. It might even be some kind of help…]

[He still did not know the details of this spirit compass. Before he was ready, he had better not attempt a second “traversal”… During the next test he had to keep a close eye on any changes in the spirit compass and the pigeon.]

[There was a link between the pigeon and himself. When he roused the spirit form fire, that link became clearer. He could even control, to some degree, where the pigeon appeared… but that was as far as his control went.]

[AI clearly had her own will. She acted according to her own thoughts, and any orders he gave her might not be obeyed. In this, she was different from the other “items” on the Vanished.]

[She could talk, had some thinking ability, and judged problems on her own… Compared with ordinary Anomalous items, this pigeon seemed closer in nature to Goathead.]

After summing up what he knew so far, Duncan finally turned his gaze to the Obsidian Dagger.

Its blade looked like a dry, twisted finger, with a black surface that gleamed faintly.

This was the very thing the black-robed priest with the golden mask of the Sun had held when he presided over the evil sacrificial rite in the underground gathering place of the sewers. Judging by how it had been used, it should be a ritual blade.

Duncan had reached that gathering place, which was probably beneath the city-state of Pland, by using mental projection, and had returned in the same way. He had thought the whole process was purely at the level of spirit or soul, but now this ritual dagger sat in front of him, very real.

After a short pause, Duncan reached out and picked up the dagger.

A cold, hard feeling spread from his palm. This was a real object.

Duncan released a trace of spirit form fire and let the flame coil around the blade. From the empty, hollow feedback, he could tell that the supernatural power that had once filled the ritual dagger had already faded away.

Just as he had judged back at the sacrificial rite site, this thing was not a true Anomaly. It was more like an extension of some supernatural power, or a temporary item “poured” full of power by artificial means.

Duncan still did not know what kind of system this world’s Anomalies followed, but he guessed this dagger was not especially rare. At the very least… it looked like something that could be produced in batches.

“Did you bring this back?” he asked, raising his head to look at AI resting on the desk. He lifted the Obsidian Dagger a little. “And you brought it especially for me?”

The pigeon stared at Duncan with its red eyes, its whole body motionless, giving no reaction at all.

Duncan: “…?”

He asked the question again. The pigeon still did not move, like a lifeless statue.

The sudden Anomalous change made Duncan frown. Just as he was about to use spirit form fire to prod AI and see if he could force her awake, the bird suddenly “came to life”. She hopped twice in place and shouted loudly:

“Pick up the Solar Axe, pick up this the Sun war axe, pick up this the Sun war axe…”

“Alright, alright, I get it. You don’t have to answer every single time I asked,” Duncan quickly waved his hand, forcing the pigeon to quiet down while he searched for the right words. “Then do you know how you brought this dagger over? Or, can you carry physical objects when you traverse? Is that it?”

The pigeon thought for a moment, then lowered its head and pecked Duncan’s finger. “Storewide discounts, free shipping on every item.”

“I’ll… just pretend I understood that,” Duncan said.

He sighed. It seemed that this was the limit of what he could communicate with the bird.

Then he rose from the desk and looked toward the enchanted sea chart room.

Goathead and Alice were still outside, locked in warm, friendly “conversation”. The doll had not made a sound for a long time, while Goathead had just started explaining the seventeenth way to cook kelp stew.

Duncan felt he had to go rescue his only current crew member out there—and the one whose “style” was actually the most normal.

On the other hand, he had been in his cabin for quite a while, and had stirred up some Anomalous movement in the meantime. He felt he should go out and show himself, just to put Goathead’s mind at ease.

But before he left, he hesitated and glanced at AI, who was running around on the desk.

Should he take the pigeon out as well? If he did, how was he supposed to explain it?

Duncan hesitated for only two seconds, then decisively grabbed the pigeon and set her on his shoulder.

He was going to operate on the Vanished for a long time, and in the foreseeable future this pigeon would surely follow him as well. He did not yet know what habits the bird had, but as an Anomalous being that could think and talk, it would be very hard to hide her away somewhere like a dead object.

Having one more “crew member” on the ship was something he could not really hide. If he tried to hide her now and she was exposed later, it would actually harm the image of “Captain Duncan” far more.

So he might as well bring the pigeon out openly and say she was his new “trophy”. He did not need to explain anything to Goathead. A captain did not owe explanations to his first mate.

The first mate would fill in the blanks himself.

As for the strange phrases the pigeon blurted out from time to time—words that would surely make no sense to the people of this world—he did not have to explain those either.

He would just let Goathead and Alice imagine it in their own way.

With the fat pigeon perched on his shoulder, Duncan straightened his clothes and his posture, then walked calmly toward the enchanted sea chart room.

The pigeon puffed out her chest proudly and cried, as if making an announcement: “Authentic Herbal Tea, the true good voice, welcome to our show, brought to you by…”

Chapter 26: Night Without Stars

To be honest, Duncan suddenly found that when the pigeon on his shoulder started talking, he could hardly walk with any composure, even if his nerves had been thicker than a main support beam.

At that moment he very much wished he could be a normal pirate captain with a parrot on his shoulder. At worst, a monkey would have been fine too.

But he had already pushed open the door to the enchanted sea chart room. It was impossible to turn back now.

In the room where the chart table stood, Goathead was cheerfully chattering away about the twelfth legend related to fish stew. The sound of the captain’s cabin door opening finally cut off this noisy fellow. His black wooden head turned at once toward Duncan, and his tone rose with obvious delight: “Ah, Captain! You finally came out. I must tell you, Miss Alice is a truly excellent conversation partner. I have not chatted so happily with anyone in many years, you know…”

Duncan ignored Goathead’s loud babbling and looked first at the victim sitting opposite the chart table. He saw a headless doll sitting very straight in the chair, holding her own head in her hands while pressing her ears tight.

Even so, Alice’s eyes still looked as empty as if she had just sat through twelve advanced math classes in a row. She did not react at all, even when Duncan walked right up to her.

Duncan: “…”

“She pulled her own head off,” Goathead explained before Duncan could speak, “though I do not know why she would do that…”

How powerful was Goathead’s endless chatter, that it could actually force a cursed Doll to pull off her own head just to resist the sound waves?!

While Duncan was still shocked by this, the overly excited Goathead finally noticed the strange newcomer the captain had brought out. His wooden head tilted a little. His pitch-black eyes suddenly fixed on the pigeon on Duncan’s shoulder: “Hm? Captain, what is that on your shoulder…”

“Her name is AI. From now on, she is my pet.” Duncan spoke in the simplest way he could, using as few sentences as possible to avoid any slipups, and at the same time he watched Goathead’s reaction to these words.

“Your pet?” Goathead was clearly stunned for a second, then he seemed to start filling in the blanks by himself. “Ah, just now the Vanished did sense you leave the ship for a short time… Did you go walking in the Spirit Realm? Is this a trophy you brought back while walking in the Spirit Realm?”

Walking in the Spirit Realm?

A term he had never heard before suddenly appeared. Duncan thought of the brass spirit compass placed in the captain’s cabin, of the handwriting left by the real Captain Duncan in the past, and of that strange soul traversal experience of projecting his soul far away. In his heart he quietly matched these things together. Once he felt his guess was almost certainly right, his expression stayed calm as he nodded: “I just went to clear my head a bit.”

As soon as Duncan finished, Goathead began to flatter him as expected: “Ah! As expected of the great Captain Duncan. Even a simple walk in the Spirit Realm lets you bring back a trophy. This is a pigeon, yes? For it to

become your pet, it must be extraordinary. You even hung your spirit compass on her. Is this perhaps… ah, of course, your judgment is always correct. But what is special about this pigeon? Could it be that she…”

From Goathead’s flattery, Duncan heard something hidden. His heart stirred as he realized that Goathead clearly recognized the brass spirit compass now hanging on AI’s chest, and that this spirit compass was obviously very important to the real Captain Duncan. So important that it should not have been casually left on some newly appeared “pet”.

But even though he sensed something was wrong, he had no way to fix it. The spirit compass was now already “bound” together with the pigeon. It even seemed that, from the feedback of controlling the flames of spirit form, the pigeon herself now felt like the true body of the spirit compass.

Duncan thought quickly, but his face stayed calm and still. While he was distracted for that brief moment, AI, who had been squatting quietly on his shoulder, suddenly let out a loud coo. Then she flapped her wings and flew right in front of Goathead.

Goathead’s pitch-black eyes locked on the pigeon at once. AI tilted her head in a very serious way and tapped his face with her beak: “Recharge some Q coins?”

Duncan: “…”

“An Anomaly with intellect?!” Goathead was also clearly stunned, but he reacted quickly, his tone full of surprise. “This pigeon can talk?!”

Duncan gently reminded him from the side: “You can talk too.”

The pigeon AI took two steps across the table, then walked away while muttering to herself: “Is this normal is this normal is this normal…”

Seeing this, Duncan rubbed his fingers together. Green flames suddenly leaped up. The pigeon pacing on the table vanished in an instant, and the

next moment she appeared back on his shoulder.

“Yes, an Anomaly with intellect. And I control her directly,” Duncan said as he nodded to Goathead. “Any other questions?”

Goathead answered at once: “Ah… of course not, of course not, then there is no problem at all. Everything is under the control of the great Captain Duncan.”

Duncan ignored Goathead after that. Once he ended the topic, he turned his attention to Alice, who was still dazed while holding her head. Maybe that earlier, broad-minded experience had made his nerves tougher, or maybe he had just gotten used to it after seeing it a few times. Now, when he looked at Alice sitting there with her head in her arms, he did not feel it was that creepy. Instead, he thought she was actually… a little cute.

He reached out and patted the doll Miss on the shoulder: “Wake up, wake up.”

Alice’s body shuddered at once, as if she had just woken from a long nightmare. The head she was holding in her hands opened its mouth and spoke: “Cap… cap… cap…”

Duncan: “Put your head back on first.”

Only then did Alice react. She hurried to put her head back in place in a fluster. With a click, the joint locked, and her voice finally flowed smoothly: “Ah, Captain, you are back? Just now it felt like… Is Mr. Goathead finished talking?”

Goathead on the table spoke at once: “No, we had just reached certain legends about fish stew. We can talk about that next time…”

Duncan cut him off with a few blunt words: “Shut up.”

“Oh.”

Beside them, Alice clearly flinched the moment Goathead opened his mouth. This proud cursed Doll actually showed a horrified expression. Even though Goathead shut his mouth at once under the captain's order, she still looked at the chart table with lingering fear.

Duncan suspected that for quite a long time in the future, this doll Miss would not dare step into the captain's cabin again.

Thinking of this, he finally asked with some curiosity: "Why did you come looking for me? What is it?"

"I…" Alice looked a bit blank, as if her original reason for visiting the captain's cabin had been completely erased by the long talk with Goathead. After a few seconds, she finally remembered. "Ah, right, I just wanted to ask if there is a place to take a bath on the ship. My wooden crate was soaked in seawater earlier, and now my joints feel a bit… uncomfortable."

By the end, the doll Miss's expression was clearly awkward. But the one who really should have felt more awkward was Duncan. After all, he was the one who had thrown that crate off the ship before.

And he had thrown it several times.

His embarrassment flashed by. Duncan forced his expression to stay steady and said in a calm tone: "Just for that?"

Alice sat on the chair, very stiff: "J-just for that."

"For many long-range sea ships, fresh water is a very precious resource. Taking a bath is a luxury and something you have to restrain," Duncan started seriously. Then he suddenly smiled a little. "But you are lucky. The Vanished is not an ordinary ship. Fresh water is not a problem here. Come with me. There is a place to bathe in the cabin under the middle deck. To get there, we have to cross the upper deck first."

Alice stood up at once. She truly did not want to stay in this place with Goathead even one more second.

Before leaving the room, Duncan looked back at Goathead: “You keep steering.”

After giving his order, he pushed open the door of the captain’s cabin and led Alice out onto the deck.

By now the veil of night already hung low.

Over the Boundless Sea, the night sky was clear.

After many days of clouds, this was the first time Duncan stood under a clear night sky in this world.

He suddenly stopped and tilted his head back, staring up at the veil of night without moving.

The sky was pitch-black and starless. No heavenly bodies existed there.

The only thing he could see was a faint, gray-white “crack” that seemed to tear open the entire sky. It stretched across the horizon, and along its edges fine cracks spread outward like ripped flesh. A dim, pale halo slowly leaked from the rift, like a stain of blood spreading through deep water.

This “Pale Scar” across the sky lit the whole Boundless Sea. It was more than twice as bright as the moonlight in Duncan’s memory.

Chapter 27: Not Enough Everyday Common Sense

In some ways, this sky with no stars or moon, only a single wound, shocked Duncan even more than that Sun trapped in rune rings.

Because no matter how much of an Anomaly the Sun was, it only shone on the world beneath his feet. In Duncan's understanding as a person from Earth, the so-called "Sun" was just one star among billions.

All the twisted Visions were limited to the space under the sunlight. Beyond that sunlight, the sky could still hold countless stars full of possibility. For a being bound by gravity, the world under the sunlight was basically the entire world. Even so, Duncan could at least understand and accept the scale of such Visions.

Yet in the night sky before him, Duncan did not see any object that could be called a "star". There were no stars, no Moon, no distant river of starlight.

There was only that torn wound, covering the heavens in a way he could not understand, sending out pale mist-like light.

The whole Boundless Sea lay under this snowy, pale night.

Beyond the Sun lay distant nothingness and even greater Visions.

Duncan did not say anything. He only stared at the sky, while countless questions and guesses circled in his mind.

Where were the other planets? Had they never existed? Or was the world under his feet a lone body in the empty vacuum of the universe, so far from all other stars that its night sky was pitch-black and starless? What was that Pale Scar stretching across the heavens? A torn rift in space? A solid, touchable structure hanging in the sky? Or simply an illusion, floating above the dangerous Boundless Sea?

“Captain?”

At last, a voice pulled Duncan out of his silence. Alice the doll watched the ghost captain, who had suddenly stopped walking, with some nervousness. She saw his face grow even darker and more serious than before, and it scared her: “Are you all right, sir? Is the sky about to change? A huge storm? I once heard the seafarers outside my crate talk about that…”

“…Nothing.”

Duncan spoke softly. Then he suddenly lowered his gaze from the sky and looked at Alice with a calm face. It sounded like an answer, and also like he was talking to himself as he repeated: “There is nothing.”

“Then we…”

Duncan walked forward again, his expression as calm as if nothing had happened: “Come on. I will take you to the cabin. You can wash there in the future too, if you need to wash.”

Once again, this world showed its strange, twisted side to the outsider, and this strangeness seemed to have no end.

Duncan already knew that he did not know how many shocking Visions were waiting for him in the future. If he got worked up every time, then his whole life would be nothing but getting worked up.

If his decades of life on Earth had given him any useful experience, then there was one lesson that helped him most now:

If a problem really existed, then find a way to solve it. A problem would not vanish just because you denied it, just as this bizarre sky would not turn into a starry one because he questioned it.

There had to be a reason for the world to look like this. Since all things could exist here, that made their existence a fact that could not be argued away. No matter how absurd or strange, they were still objective reality. If he could not understand it for the moment, that was his problem, not the world's.

As the current captain of the Vanished, Duncan felt he would probably have a long time to slowly get to know this world.

Alice did not know why the captain stayed silent along the way. She only knew that the air around Duncan suddenly grew heavy. Yet after they reached the target cabin, that heavy feeling faded at once.

Duncan brought the doll Miss to the place where she could bathe. It was a bathroom prepared for the higher ranking seafarers. For a classical sailing ship, such a bathroom was a kind of "luxury" facility. Normally, it would never be for common sailors.

In ancient times, life on sailing ships during long ocean voyages had been very harsh. Limited fresh water, rotten food, terrible medical care, and the mental pressure of long journeys troubled every explorer who dared to challenge the sea. On Earth, many of these problems were not fully solved even by the early industrial age.

From what Duncan knew, early sailing Ocean-Going Vessels on Earth did not even have toilets prepared for regular crew members. Ordinary sailors usually handled their personal needs on grating boards hanging over the sea, which also meant they had to watch the wind direction. Bathing was an even harder problem. Using spare sails as bathtubs and washing with

seawater was how many easygoing sailors solved it. Many seafarers in the age of sail simply chose not to bathe for weeks or even months.

After all, compared to scurvy, the plague, and mass hysteria born from crushing mental pressure, a bit of hygiene trouble was the least of their worries.

Yet, ironically, on this ghost ship that everyone feared, those harsh living problems were solved.

The freshwater tank on the Vanished refilled itself. The food stored in the hold showed no sign of rotting. The ghost captain could not get sick, and Alice's neck problems were not caused by life at sea.

Aside from the frequent spikes in blood pressure when dealing with Goathead, this ship was actually quite livable.

"The pipe next to the tub leads to the freshwater tank. You can draw water straight from it. The plug for the tub hangs over there, do not lose it. For now the conditions are limited, so the ship does not supply hot water, but I do not think that will bother you," Duncan said as he introduced the facilities in the cabin. These simple bits of knowledge were the result of his own exploration over the past few days.

"Just being able to rinse my body is enough. Having salt water in the joints really does not feel good," Alice was not picky at all. She looked around the cabin with curiosity and excitement while listening to Duncan. She nodded as she spoke: "I am only a doll. I do not care much about hot baths."

Duncan nodded, then his expression turned a little odd. He glanced at Alice and spoke with some hesitation: "By the way, do you know how to take a bath? Do you have this kind of… everyday experience?"

Alice really froze for a moment. Then, thinking carefully, she answered very seriously: "I think… it should be fine? I just need to take my joints

apart and rinse them, then put them back on after washing…”

Duncan: “…?”

He looked at Alice. Alice looked back at him with an innocent face.

“Have you thought about how you are going to put them back on after you take them all apart?” Duncan realized that his casual question had hit the mark. This doll who had never left her crate really had no experience in this area. “I cannot help you with that.”

Alice: “…That is true, I guess.”

“And I strongly suggest that you do not take your joints apart too often,” Duncan added with some feeling. “Even if your body structure allows it.”

Alice looked confused: “Why?”

“If you take them apart too often, they will start to fall off,” Duncan said at last, unable to keep the helpless tone from his voice. He had never imagined that living on a ship with a cursed Doll would come with this many ‘little details’. No novel, film, or drama had ever covered that. “I do not want you suddenly falling to pieces in front of me while walking on the deck one day. There is no one on this ship who knows how to maintain a doll’s joints.”

He paused, then added: “Your neck problem is already bad enough.”

Alice pictured that scene and immediately shrank her neck: “Ah, all right, all right, I understand… I know what to do now…”

“You had better,” Duncan said. He looked again at this doll whose life experience was not very complete, still a bit worried. Then he turned to leave. “I have many other things to do. Try not to cause too much trouble.”

“Yes, Captain. Thank you, Captain,” Alice said happily. But just as Duncan was about to step out of the cabin, she suddenly spoke again: “Ah, right, Captain…”

Duncan stopped and turned his head a little: “What is it?”

“Captain… I suddenly feel like you are not that scary,” Alice looked at his back and chose her words carefully. “Goathead said you are the most terrifying captain on the Boundless Sea, the most unpredictable disaster on all the route, but…”

“But what?”

“But you seem pretty easy to talk to. You even feel a bit like a worried parent…”

Duncan did not turn around. After two seconds of silence, he suddenly asked: “Where did you get the idea of a family… Do you have a family?”

Alice hesitated at once, then slowly shook her head: “I do not think so.”

“Then do not talk about parents. Just stay on the ship and behave. I will make the arrangements for your life on this ship.”

“Oh. Yes, Captain.”

Chapter 28: Pale Night

Life in the Mortal Realm was not the same as life in strange stories. The biggest difference was that when you lived in the Mortal Realm, you had to think about a whole pile of real and trivial details –

Did a moving cursed doll need joint maintenance? Would Alice, who took her joints apart all the time, someday fall to pieces in the middle of a walk? Had the salted meat and hard cheese on the ghost ship actually gone bad?

What about superheroes who entertained guests by day and fought evil at night – did they ever sleep? And after fighting a superhero, did the forces of evil still have to go to the market for groceries?

Stories never talked about these things. People in stories always came and went like the wind, dressed in spotless white. The cursed doll in a story only needed to crawl out of some dark corner to frighten people. The ghost captain in a story never had to worry that all the salted meat and hard cheese on his ship had expired a century ago.

But a cursed doll in the Mortal Realm felt itchy all over after soaking in seawater, and even taking a bath meant thinking on the spot about how to clean the grains of salt out of every joint…

Standing outside the cabin, Duncan sighed. He now saw even more clearly that surviving on this ship for a long time would take more than just determination.

He also had to think about a whole stack of practical problems, especially now that the number of crew members had increased.

There were actually not many daily supplies on this ghost ship. Duncan knew that very well.

This ship had an unlimited supply of fresh water, but that was the only thing that was unlimited. The food in the hold would not refill itself once eaten, and the only edible things there were salted meat and hard cheese. Because of the Vanished's special nature, they showed no sign of rot, but Duncan still had good reason to suspect they had been stored for at least a century.

Besides that, this ship had no spare clothes that fit Alice's size, though the cursed doll had never mentioned needing any. There was nothing for leisure either – not even a chessboard or a deck of cards.

The Boundless Sea was vast and endless, yet it was very hard for the Vanished to get real supplies from this wide ocean. The ship seemed to have no reliable home port where it could rest and refit, and it had no channel at all to trade with the civilized city-states on land.

Goathead seemed to pay no attention to such problems, but Duncan was already thinking about them seriously. He had to find a way to improve the Vanished's current shortage of supplies.

Beyond that, he was also thinking about how to build contact with the city-states on land.

Drifting blindly on the sea forever was an extremely inefficient way to explore. Information about this world had to be taken from the land. This was Duncan's deepest realization after his walk through the Spirit Realm.

Even aside from that, for the sake of his own body and mind, he needed to try to have more contact with those city-states on land, to touch the civilized society of this world. Otherwise, after drifting for so long, he really was afraid he would turn into a twisted, gloomy, reclusive ghost captain.

Thinking of this, Duncan turned his head a little and looked at the pigeon AI, who was squatting obediently on his shoulder, preening her feathers.

His gaze mainly fell on the brass spirit compass on AI's chest.

The pigeon tilted her head at her Master and suddenly blurted out: "Open a branch base! Lay down fungal carpet! Hey, do you even know how to run things?"

For a moment Duncan fell silent. This pigeon seemed deranged most of the time, yet every now and then the words she blurted out hit so exactly on point that he could not help wondering if she was acting stupid on purpose.

For now, walking in the Spirit Realm seemed to be the only workable way to "go" to the city-states on land.

Even though this method seemed to have far too many uncertainties, and the last time he used it a mysterious accident like "AI" had appeared, Duncan knew he would soon make another walk in the Spirit Realm. It was not only to gather information from the land, but also to test and master a very useful ability as quickly as possible.

Just as important as Spirit Realm walking was AI the pigeon's "special ability" to bring back a ritual knife from far-off land.

If she could bring back a knife, could she bring back more things? What were the rules and limits on the items this bird could carry? Could this process be controlled by people?

After thinking for a while, Duncan decided to ask the pigeon directly: "Do you know how you brought that knife back?"

The pigeon thought for a moment, then said in a deep tone: "You need more crystal ore."

Duncan: "…"

He decided to give up talking with this pigeon for now. It would be more reliable to try this himself the next time he carried out a Spirit Realm walk.

…

Inside the cabin, Alice finally figured out, with some fumbling, how to use the water pipes, and roughly worked out how she was supposed to take a bath.

On a ghost ship with such limited conditions, she could only bathe in cold water, but for a doll, that was no problem at all.

But before jumping into the tub, Alice decided to greet everything in the cabin first.

She patted the huge oak tub, then knocked on the pillars that held up the cabin. She tapped the floor with the tips of her shoes, then stood on tiptoe to tug at the ropes and hooks hanging from the ceiling.

“Hello, my name is Alice,” she said happily to all these cold objects, greeting them the same way she had greeted that Mr. Goathead earlier. “From now on, I will be living on this ship.”

Nothing in the cabin answered her greeting, but Alice did not mind at all.

Goathead had said that the Vanished was alive, and that many things on this ship were alive.

Even though they did not seem to have real minds like Goathead, and could not even communicate, that did not stop Alice from treating the whole Vanished as a “neighbor” who needed to be greeted.

The Vanished was a living thing, and so was she.

Sure that her greeting had been polite and proper, Alice felt even happier. Then she took off her fine dress and clumsily climbed into the oak tub that was now filled with water.

First step, take off her head and rinse it – her neck joint was not very strong anyway.

Miss Doll felt that her plan was very reasonable.

…

In the deep night, the city-state of Pland finally ended a whole day of noise. Under the pale glow of the night sky, this prosperous “Sea Jewel” slowly sank into sleep.

But in the still darkness, the gaze of the Night Watcher watched over the sleeping city.

On the highest building in Pland, the Great Bell Tower, a young woman with long gray-white hair and an unusually tall, straight figure stood at the window, looking down at the city.

Her features were very beautiful, but a striking scar across her left eye made her look fearsome. She was taller than most men and wore light silver-gray armor and a battle skirt. Her body clearly had been well trained, with full, well-shaped muscles in all her limbs. Within easy reach beside her lay a greatsword that gave off a faint silver glow. Runes shaped like waves were carved into the sword’s hilt, and dim light shimmered along the blade like rippling water.

Behind the woman came the constant sound of machinery. The movement of the Great Bell Tower was running smoothly, driven by a steam engine. Complex and precise gears and linkages ran through the roof and the floor, turning the four clock faces above and the Mimicry Orrery hidden deep inside the building.

From the sound alone, this huge and delicate machine was in excellent condition. No evil power had disturbed its sacred steam core.

But Inquisitor Vanna still felt a faint unease. A bad premonition gnawed at her, as if something was about to happen, or had already happened, and she was fated to be powerless before it.

Footsteps came from the stairway. The gray-haired woman turned toward the sound and saw a priest in the long robe of a sea priest coming up from the stairwell. The priest held a copper censer in his hand, and clean-smelling smoke slowly coiled around him.

The priest walked to the central pillar of the movement in the room. He took down the old censer hanging on the pillar's rail and hung up the new one. He watched the smoke drifting from the censer and made sure it floated unhindered among the turning gears and linkages. Only then did he softly recite the name of the Storm Goddess and turn to look at the gray-haired woman standing at the window.

"Good night, Inquisitor. You are standing night watch in person again?"

"I keep having a bad feeling. It has been this way for days – tonight it is even stronger."

"A bad feeling? About what?" The priest lifted his head, worry in his deep eyes. "Did the Goddess send you a prophetic vision?"

"It is not that clear," the young female Inquisitor shook her head. "I only vaguely feel… something is drawing near this city."

Chapter 29: The People Who Protect the City

Gods of supreme power dwelled in the keystones of this world. With sight beyond time and space, they cast their gaze on the workings of the world. Devout believers who turned their hearts toward a god and held the power of Spiritual Insight could, through their secret link with the God, glimpse some part of the Mortal Realm’s future, or changes taking place at that moment in some hidden corner of the world.

This kind of sight was not bound by time or space, but it carried the hidden risk of corruption by Subspace. For devout believers with firm wills, however, this dangerous and powerful gift was their greatest reliance when they guarded the fragile lights of civilization scattered across the endless sea.

Inquisitor Vanna had seen a similar vision for several days in a row.

In a half-dreaming state, she saw the boundless sea darken like ink. Then a thunderous roar rose from the depths. The sea split in two, and a terrible trench opened straight down to the seabed. A huge ship wreathed in flames rose from the ocean floor and slowly floated upward in midair like a flying vessel. Behind it walked an invisible giant, its whole body covered in starlight, taking step after step toward the city-state of Pland.

In Inquisitor Vanna’s life so far, a prophetic vision on such a terrifying scale had appeared only twice.

The first came in her childhood. She woke from a nightmare overflowing with blood, and soon after, in an attack by cultists, she lost her parents and received the scar that would stay on her face for life.

The second came four years ago. In a dream she saw a Black Sun rise beneath the city-state, and because of it she wiped out the largest cell of the Sun cult that had slipped into the city. To this day, the cultists' lingering minions still hid in the vast, complex, ancient tunnels under Pland, locked in a pointless struggle with the Church's Guardians.

This was the third time. She saw a ship return from the Deep Sea, bringing an unnameable giant back into this world.

She had lied to the priest before her. The prophetic vision she saw was in fact very clear – so clear that even she, an Inquisitor, had been unable to sleep for days.

The priest looked into the calm gray-white eyes of the woman before him and hesitated for a long time before speaking: "But when you prayed to the Goddess, you did not seem to receive a bad answer?"

"The Goddess does not have to warn us of every risk. Sometimes hardship itself is the test," Vanna said calmly. "Enough about that. What news is there from the Explorer Association?"

The priest nodded at once: "The contact at the Association just sent word. The sacred relic kept at their headquarters has sensed that ship appear in the southwestern sea. But the telegraph apparatus on board seems to have broken down. Right now we cannot contact them. We only know that the ship is moving at its normal speed and on its normal course toward the coastal waters near Pland."

"It vanished from the sacred relic's senses for a time, then appeared out of nowhere on another stretch of sea far off its planned route. Now it cannot be

contacted and is sailing straight toward the city… and before it went missing, it was on a mission to escort an Anomaly.” The Inquisitor’s brows slowly drew together. Years of dealing with eerie things made her instincts prickle with warning. “If I remember right, that ship is called the White Oak, isn’t it?”

“Yes, the White Oak. Its captain is Lawrence Creed of the Explorer Association, a very experienced captain. Because of the special cargo, the Church was informed before the ship left the city-state of Lunsa.” The priest tried to recall the details as he spoke. “Ah, and the priest traveling with them is a registered priest of the Deep Sea Church.”

“So they are our brothers of the Church… I hope things are not too bad,” Vanna said gravely. “In any case, something is wrong with that ship. The entire route from Lunsa to Pland lies inside the Explorer Association’s safe zone. Yet that ship vanished once from the sacred relic’s senses. I suspect the White Oak very likely left the Mortal Realm for a short time, and may even have gone somewhere it should never go.”

“Inform the Guardians at the Harbor. As soon as the White Oak enters port, they are to keep it under watch. Until all inspections are complete, no person and no item may leave that ship. Has the Security Corps responded?”

“Rest assured. Your uncle – the Governor – has already ordered the constables to secure the area around the Harbor and has raised the Harbor’s alert level. From now until the alert is lifted, all ships entering or leaving Pland will temporarily dock at the backup Harbor on the western side.”

“Good. My uncle has always been a cautious man.” The tight look on Vanna’s face finally eased a little. “As long as he does not let those ordinary people in the Security Corps get mixed up in this.”

The priest looked into Vanna's pale gray eyes, chose his words with care, and asked: "Do you think… that ship has already been corrupted?"

"We cannot be sure yet. But a ship that briefly leaves the Mortal Realm and then returns is rarely completely normal. Perhaps some item on board has unknowingly changed into an Anomaly. Perhaps it is some hidden mental illness in a crew member. It might even be an extra sailor or a captain who has been replaced. For a sea ship that has already shown abnormal signs, it is never wrong to treat it with the highest caution."

"Ah… I hope that ship and its crew are all safe," the priest said, placing his hand over his chest and murmuring the name of the Storm Goddess. "May the Storm Goddess protect all who bravely challenge the sea."

"May they all be safe," Vanna echoed softly, lowering her eyes. Then, as if to remind the priest before her, she added: "But if they are not so fortunate, we must also be ready."

"Yes. I understand."

Vanna nodded. She was about to turn her attention back to the city outside the window when hurried footsteps suddenly sounded from the stairs.

Moments later, a Guardian in a black uniform trimmed with silver ran up from the stairwell, the emblem of waves and a dagger painted on his chest.

"Inquisitor!" The young Guardian took two quick breaths, then spoke urgently: "We have found a worship site of the Sun cult in the sewers and captured a group of cultists!"

Vanna's face grew sharply serious at once: "Those cultists who worship the Black Sun? Wait – you said you found a worship site, not a hiding place? They dared to hold ritual Worship again?!"

"Yes. It was a place used to hold rituals. We found evidence that sacrificial rites had been performed there," the Guardian said quickly. "We also found

a large number of victims in a nearby chamber not far from the ritual site – most of them had had their hearts taken in sacrifice. Only… something about the ritual site itself is not quite right."

From the Guardian's face Vanna saw a mix of absurdity and confusion. She took up the heavy greatsword beside her, the one that bore the Storm Goddess's divine blessing, slung it onto her back, and strode quickly toward the stairs: "Lead the way. I will go to the scene myself."

"Yes!"

The heavy, blessed greatsword clinked against her metal shoulder guards with a clear sound. Her quick steps carried her down the long stairs inside the Great Bell Tower. Vanna came out onto the small square in front of the tower and saw several Guardian squad members already gathered there, waiting. Two Steam Walkers stood at the edge of the square, their spider-like mechanical bodies giving off constant clicking sounds.

Vanna did not stop. She only gave the Guardians a signal to move out and walked straight toward one of the walkers. The huge machine, as large as two double-wheel carriages, looked like a mechanical spider crouched on the ground. Wheels were set along the edges of its steel limbs to let it glide over flat ground, and steel hooks were mounted for rough terrain. On either side of the upper carapace were gun pods fitted with rotary guns.

Purely technological creations had a hard time harming Anomalies or Visions directly. But overwhelming firepower could wipe out the heretic cultists hiding behind them and pulling the strings. Of course, these machines could not show their full power in the sewers, but they were very useful for blocking off exits.

A spray of holy 8-millimeter rounds could, in the blink of an eye, send a whole crowd of fleeing heretics off to Subspace to serve their master.

The gray-haired, gray-eyed Inquisitor leaped straight onto the walker’s carapace. With the sword on her back, she stood steady in the night. Two other Guardians climbed skillfully into the gun pods on either side of the carapace. A series of hissing sounds came from the cylinders and pressure pipes as they built up and released steam. White vapor sprayed from the joints of the walker’s limbs. The huge mechanical spider rose, jumped in a single stride onto the nearest main road, then switched to gliding mode and sped toward the closest sewer entrance.

Chapter 30: Traces of Ruin

The huge, heavy mechanical spider folded its long, jointed legs up against its belly and used the wheel structures on the outside of those legs to race along the flat road. Inquisitor Vanna stood steady on the metal shell of the machine as if she had been cast onto it. The night wind, carrying a faint smell of the sea, swept through the streets. The cold air made her mind even clearer.

The cultists who worshipped the god the Sun were a deadly hidden threat to modern civilization. Unfortunately, this kind of hidden threat was not the only one.

Malicious gazes were always watching from the depths of Subspace, fixed on the Mortal Realm. Foolish mortals were always trying to reach for those ominous powers. Between the dealings of Elder Gods and mortals, twisted entities left behind from ancient times, forbidden spawn, and lingering echoes of corruption hid deep inside the city-states. They were always stirring, always ready to move, trying to pry apart the order that held society together.

Among all these threats, the Suntists were the ones that made the Guardians of the city-state of Pland the most wary and the most troubled.

They were not only cultists, but also products of a lost part of the Old World’s history. Compared with most foolish and blind ordinary cults, the most dangerous thing about these heretics who worshipped the Black Sun was that they actually had a kind of “faith”. It was fanatical and twisted, and their lower ranks were a messy mix of all sorts of people, but in the

upper levels of this hateful cult, there really was a “core belief” that had not changed for hundreds of years.

This belief centered on the “Age of Order” under the ancient light of the Sun. It formed its own complete system, and they even had a matching “true Solar calendar” that modern civilization refused to recognize. They firmly believed they were the descendants of an ancient civilization that had long been lost, and that this glorious ancient civilization would one day rise again.

As an inquisitor of the Deep Sea Church, Vanna had little interest in the cultists’ twisted theories, but she knew that it was these very ideas that gave the Suntists a unity and stubbornness far beyond that of other heretics. Because of this, they could survive strike after strike and keep growing in the shadows of many city-states.

Even so, the way they had suddenly sprung back to life in Pland still surprised Vanna.

After the huge crackdown four years ago, the believers of the Sun inside Pland had been badly weakened. According to several investigation reports, those heretics had already moved most of their key members to nearby city-states like Lunsa, Morka, and even farther Cold Harbor. The ones left in Pland were only some stubborn fools who had been bewitched, and who were not important enough to follow the bishops when they moved.

These lackeys hid in the sewers. They survived only by using their knowledge of the underground and the bit of twisted divine blessing the Black Sun had given them to dodge the Guardians’ hunts. Four years passed. Their numbers kept shrinking, and all they could do now was struggle on and cling to life.

Yet today, four years later, they had suddenly gathered again. They even dared, at the risk of exposing themselves, to hold a sacrificial ritual in a

public assembly hall. Who had given them such courage?

Or rather… was something big about to happen in this city-state? Was there some reason strong enough that those cultists would risk having their last tiny spark stamped out, just to draw the gaze of the Black Sun onto Pland?

From inside the mechanical spider came the vibration and noise of its steam core running at full speed. A faint scent of incense drifted out from its pressure vents and was carried over by the night wind. Vanna forced herself to stop these wild thoughts and looked up at the sky.

World’s Wound hung high in the night sky. Its pale light poured down, shining on the uneven roofs, chimneys, and towers of Pland. The strike team was passing along the edge of the industrial district. Huge steam and hot-fluid pipes stretched between the factories, crossing overhead like the blood vessels of giants threading through the sky above the streets.

Vanna vaguely remembered the past, the night that was burned deepest into her memory and was also the most terrifying. That midnight, thick with the smell of blood, her uncle had carried her on his back as he fled from a sea of fire. The streets were full of walking corpses trapped in a mass hallucination and shadows of swollen, shrinking flesh. They had escaped along the factory pipes, while the stink of blood and the chemical oil seeping from the pipes made her want to retch.

A sudden jolt ran through the mechanical spider under her feet. Vanna snapped out of her memories.

The flat road came to an end. Ahead lay an abandoned area on the edge of the city. The road surface there was full of holes and dips, uneven and rough. The two mechanical spiders left their gliding mode. They stretched their long legs out again and began to race forward at high speed over the bumpy ground.

Before long, the team reached an abandoned sewer entrance.

Another eight-person squad was already waiting there. They had sealed off the area around the entrance to keep any unrelated people from getting close.

Vanna greeted the subordinates here, then followed the officer in charge straight down into the depths of the sewer.

They passed through deep corridors and filthy narrow paths. In the end, Vanna reached the secret assembly hall. Here, she saw more guardian warriors, as well as Church priests who were carrying out a purification ritual.

A temporary sacrificial altar stood in the center of the hall. The wooden platform looked as if it had been burned by fire. On top of it she could still see the desecrated totem built by the Suntists. The totem had already been burned, but its basic structure was still complete.

Around the platform were dozens of cultists, their hands tied, squatting on the ground. Most of them were shaking with fear. A few moved their lips, muttering their blasphemous prayers in silence.

But with the ritual site destroyed and the storm goddess already watching this place, these heretics' prayers were useless.

Not far from the sacrificial altar lay the bodies of the victims found in nearby caverns. These sad, murdered people had been placed on linen sheets covered in runes. Morticians who had rushed here were checking the condition of each corpse.

Several Church priests walked around the sacrificial altar. The bronze chains in their hands swayed softly. The censers at the ends of the chains gave off pure white smoke. Wherever the smoke touched the ground near the altar, it was instantly dyed with an ominous black shadow, and then

more white smoke washed over it and carried that corruption away. The breath of the Black Sun left here would be cleared bit by bit in this process.

“Inquisitor, please come this way. This is where we found something strange,” a young guardian said, pointing at a few bodies beside the sacrificial altar. “Please be careful. The ground here is not very clean.”

Vanna walked straight toward the bodies. When she saw the state of one of them, she frowned without thinking.

It was a cultist wearing a Golden Sun mask. There was no doubt he was the priest directly in charge of the sacrificial ritual at this defiled altar.

There was a terrible hole in the middle of his chest.

“…What is going on here?” Vanna frowned. “Did this fanatic heretic get too worked up at the end of the ritual and end up sacrificing himself too? I have never heard of the cultists of the Black Sun having such a rule.”

“That is exactly what is so strange. He did not sacrifice himself,” the guardian who had brought Vanna over said at once, shaking his head. His expression looked a little odd. “According to the cultists we captured at the scene… their ‘envoy’ was sacrificed by a sacrificial victim.”

“Sacrificed by a sacrificial victim?” Vanna raised her eyebrows. “What kind of nonsense is that?”

“It really does sound like nonsense.” The guardian spread his hands helplessly. “In fact, when we got here, most of the cultists were already half-mad.”

“Already half-mad?”

“Yes. Their sacrificial ritual clearly went very wrong. Many of them fell into madness. Some had even started hacking each other to pieces. They all seemed to see each other as… ‘monsters’ possessed by some terrible thing.

It was because they rushed out of the hall in their madness that they alarmed the constables on patrol nearby and exposed the whole affair. By the time we arrived, there were only a few who could still stay clear-headed and answer questions. And those last few who could still speak clearly all insisted that a sacrificial victim sacrificed the envoy."

"Madness? Cutting each other down? And they thought others were monsters possessed by something?" Vanna's expression grew serious at once. "Have you checked them? Was it caused by corruption from the Black Sun?"

"We could not find any marks of outside corruption. It looks more like a kind of spontaneous madness. The thing that drove them mad seems rooted inside their own minds," the guardian said. He lifted his hand and pointed at a young woman in a black dress who was moving among the cultists. "Heidi is already here. If we can confirm that these cultists have not been corrupted by the Black Sun, we will have to try using hypnosis."

Chapter 31: Remnants

Vanna looked up at the woman in the black dress who was checking the cultists' mental state. The woman noticed her gaze, looked up as well, and gave her a small nod.

The woman looked only a bit over twenty, yet she had a calm, steady air that felt far more mature than her age. Her black hair was coiled up at the back of her head. Pale blue crystal earrings hung from her ears, catching and reflecting the light of a nearby gas lamp when they swung.

"…Heidi is here too… Did City Hall send her?" Vanna asked the young guardian beside her.

"No. When this happened, Heidi just happened to be nearby. She came as soon as she heard the news. Is that a problem?"

"No, nothing is wrong. Heidi may be an employee of City Hall, but she has worked with the Church for a long time. We can just file a field record afterward," Vanna said, shaking her head. She quickly turned her attention back to the matter at hand. As she examined the cult priest who had lost his mind and died, she asked casually: "What else did the cultists who could still talk say? What was the situation at the time?"

"Their words were very confused. Two of them said that the normal sacrificial ritual had already ended. Then someone suddenly caught a runaway sacrificial victim near the hall. So the envoy decided to offer this sacrificial victim to the Sun," the guardian said, trying to recall the details. "Those two cultists were standing far from the altar and did not see clearly

what happened on the platform. They only said that the sacrificial victim had a hole through his heart but did not die. Instead, he shouted the Sun's name at the top of his lungs and named the envoy as the new sacrificial victim. Then the envoy was sacrificed."

"…A person chosen as a sacrificial victim called out the name of an eldritch god on the spot and just like that turned the ritual leader into the one who got sacrificed?" Vanna felt as if she had heard some wild story. It sounded absurd, but these words came from a guardian of the Church who had been strictly trained and was loyal and reliable. She had no choice but to take it seriously, and her expression grew strange. "How could something so ridiculous happen? If this really worked, then at all those cult rituals, wouldn't any victim who could talk fast enough be able to turn the tables and kill the heretic priests?"

"Exactly. Even the worst priest still holds absolute control when leading a ritual. How could a weak ordinary person push the ritual into such a runaway state with a single sentence? Besides, we have examined this priest. He clearly bears the marks of corruption from projections coming from the deep layers of the world. He was a true 'baptized one'. And according to the cultists at the scene, he was holding a ritual dagger with divine blessing at the time…"

The young guardian shook his head as he spoke, then walked over to another body lying nearby.

"But… please take a look at this. This is the 'sacrificial victim' who turned on the priest."

Vanna glanced at the guardian, then let her gaze fall on the lifeless corpse. In the next second her eyes sharpened.

It was a thin young man. He was so skinny that his build was closer to that of a boy. The most striking anomaly on his body was the empty hole in his

chest.

“…He had already been sacrificed…”

“Yes. This was a sacrificial victim who had already been offered up,” the guardian said in a serious tone. “Judging from the traces at the scene and the cultists’ statements, this ‘sacrificial victim’ had probably already lost his heart before he was pushed onto the platform. So the real situation then was that a walking corpse, in front of everyone, went up onto the platform and killed the priest leading the ritual, treating him as the new sacrificial victim.”

“…A necromancer’s trick?” Vanna muttered to herself as she thought it through. “No. The power of the Black Sun greatly restrains necromancers. Their walking corpses could never stroll right up to the totem of the Black Sun. Was it a revenant controlled by some anomaly?”

“Have you checked the lighting nearby?” she suddenly asked, looking up at the guardian beside her. “Within five hundred meters, is there any underground space that is completely dark?”

“We checked. There are no lightless caverns. Even cultists know how dangerous lightless caverns are. In the caves where they dumped bodies, they still left torches and oil lamps. They were very careful about that.”

Vanna did not speak for a moment. She bent down over the young man’s body, filled with doubt. She carefully examined the “sacrificial victim” who had, in front of so many witnesses, managed to sacrifice an extraordinary priest and send the ritual into a complete runaway state. At the same time, she reached out and lifted the corpse’s stiff eyelid, trying to find some trace left by heretical power.

Suddenly, it seemed as if a faint light flashed at the edge of her vision. She thought she saw the young man’s corpse crack its eyes open a little. Pale

green fire flickered in the empty eyeballs. A tiny spark leapt out and landed on the tip of her extended right index finger, then drifted away on the wind.

Vanna’s gaze turned cold. In an instant she drew the dagger at her waist with her left hand and, without any hesitation, sliced off her own right index finger. Then she reversed her grip and drove the dagger straight into the corpse’s forehead. The priest’s dagger, its blade covered in runes, suddenly burst into roaring flames that swallowed the corpse whole.

She took less than a second to do all of this. By the time the fire engulfed the body, she had already straightened up and stepped back two paces. She pulled out a small bottle of holy oil, which had been blessed with divine power, from her belt. She bit out the cork and poured the oil onto her right hand, which was gushing blood. When the holy oil touched flesh and blood, it gave off a loud hiss and thick white smoke.

Stabbing pain rushed through her hand, but Vanna’s face did not change at all. She saw that the guardian who had been beside her all this time had already drawn the steel sword at his waist. With one stroke, he chopped off the head of the “sacrificial victim” burning in the flames. Then he threw a dose of medicine into the fire, a mixture of seaweed extract and silver powder.

With sharp crackling blasts and flames that surged up almost to the ceiling, the twisted corpse turned to ash in the blink of an eye.

The fierce fire did not spread to any of the other bodies nearby.

The guardians around them had all reacted. Half of them drew runic steel swords and closed in around Vanna. The other half pulled out large-caliber revolvers and quickly formed a ring of guards farther out. The two priests on site also drew revolvers from beneath their robes. As they pointed the guns at the raving cultists who had grown restless because of the sudden

change, they held censers over the gun barrels, blessed the weapons with divine power, and chanted the name of the storm goddess Gamona.

“Inquisitor!” The young guardian with the steel sword finally rushed to Vanna’s side. “Are you all right? Just now…”

“There was some kind of power left in that ‘sacrificial victim’. It slipped past all the protections the goddess gave me and even past my psychic ward,” Vanna said, waving her hand. Her gaze dropped to her right hand. The goddess’s gift was taking effect. The finger cut off by the dagger was wriggling as it slowly grew back. Yet even as the pain slowly faded, she did not feel any calmer.

“Something is wrong. This was not just the work of the Black Sun. Some other powerful force also visited this sacrificial ritual… and that force has not fully left. It still wants something,” the inquisitor said quickly, making her judgment. “Move everyone and everything we have seized to the Cathedral and keep them under strict watch. All further examinations and interrogations will be done inside the Cathedral. This whole site must go through complete purification. Is there anyone else in the area?”

A guardian beside her answered at once: “Yes. We rescued a group of people from another cavern nearby. They were imprisoned as ‘future sacrificial victims’. They are being kept in a nearby pipe room for now.”

“Take them too. Bring them all to the Cathedral. They may be victims, but they must still go through strict checks before we send them home,” Vanna said quickly. Then she seemed to remember something. “Where is Heidi? Is she all right?”

“I am here.” A calm female voice sounded nearby. The woman in the black dress, the “psychiatrist” hired by City Hall, walked over at an unhurried pace and nodded to Vanna. “Do not worry. I did not react at all just now. So what exactly happened?”

“…Just like in many classic tales, the cultists provoked something more evil than themselves,” Vanna said, giving the “psychiatrist” a look. “I strongly suggest that when you examine these cultists and put them under hypnosis later, you add extra layers of protection. Something that should not have appeared showed up here… and it has left remnants behind.”

Chapter 32

As the night faded, the Pale Scar that filled the whole sky also slowly dissolved. Duncan stood on the aft deck, head tilted back, using his gaze on the sky. He did not let any detail of this moment between night and day escape him.

He saw the scar become transparent and unreal bit by bit, like a dream slowly waking. The gray-white mist of light that leaked from it merged with the sky first, then the scar itself. Throughout the whole process, the position of that “scar” never changed.

Duncan blinked as more guesses rose in his mind. Since the mark in the sky did not shift, did that mean it was not some distant astronomical structure? Did it mean it was only a phantom “printed” on the background of the atmosphere, moving in sync with the Boundless Sea?

Or was it because the planet on which the Boundless Sea lay—if this really was a planet—and that scar happened to move in perfect step with each other? Or was the scar actually moving, but his observation time was too short for the naked eye to notice?

All kinds of guesses rose and fell in his mind, but Duncan knew very well that until he had enough evidence and reliable experiments, these were only guesses. A natural phenomenon could have countless possible explanations, but without theory and proof, everything was empty talk.

The Sun rose.

First, a golden glow appeared along the line where sea met sky. Then a huge glowing structure suddenly rose from the sea. Wrapped in magnificent, blazing light, the spherical glowing orb locked in place by double layers of rune structure appeared in Duncan’s sight.

Driven by the slow turning of the rune structures, the Sun rose in solemn majesty. The imposing process seemed to carry a sound with it—a deep, powerful, slow rumble echoed faintly in Duncan’s mind. But when he really focused to listen, the sound suddenly vanished.

He frowned, wondering if he had only imagined it, yet the memory of that sound was so clear that he could not deny it.

Was that… a proclamation the Sun sent to this world as it rose? Or just one of the many illusions brought by the Boundless Sea?

No one could answer Duncan’s doubts. The vast Boundless Sea kept all its secrets as always.

The pigeon AI squatted comfortably on Duncan’s shoulder as usual. Then AI suddenly stood up, flapping its wings hard. It stared at the sea and loudly chattered: “Get some fries! Get some fries!”

Duncan could not help but laugh. He glanced at the strange pigeon and suddenly felt that having this bird around was not so bad. The odd phrases it blurted out from time to time always gave him a bit of “hometown” familiarity.

“Sadly, there are no fries on this ship,” he said, flicking the pigeon’s beak as he turned toward the captain’s cabin. “But you are right about one thing. We need to get something to eat.”

A short while later, the captain of the Vanished had prepared a traditional ghost ship breakfast for himself. In the captain’s cabin, Duncan simply used the chart table as a dining table, setting a few plates on the empty space

beside the enchanted sea chart. Today's breakfast was the same as yesterday's dinner, yesterday's lunch, and every meal before that: jerky, cheese, and plain water.

Duncan sat at the chart table and carefully, almost ritualistically, spread a napkin over his lap. Goathead sat quietly opposite him. On his left was the cursed Doll Alice, who had come early to say hello. The strange pigeon squatted on the tabletop to his right.

Duncan suddenly felt that this scene finally fit his ghost ship captain persona. There was the goat wood carving that represented demons, the cursed Doll he could not throw away, the talkative bird that knew knowledge from other worlds, and the ghost ship captain seated at the head of the table. If someone took a picture, it could go on a movie poster without any editing…

But only the people on the Vanished knew what the food situation on board was really like.

Duncan sighed and looked down at the food on his plate. The movie-poster opening scene was over. What came next was the real life of firewood, rice, oil, and salt aboard the Vanished.

He picked up his knife and pressed it hard into the cheese. The scrape of hard things rubbing together gave off a squeaking sound. Then he poked the jerky beside it with his fork, and the jerky hit the plate with a clear, ringing clink.

Alice watched this curiously and finally could not help asking: "Captain, today's food is the same as yesterday's, right?"

"Tomorrow's will be the same too," Duncan said, looking up at the cursed Doll. "Do you want to try some?"

Alice thought for a moment, then picked up a strip of jerky with her hand. She put it in her mouth and chewed twice, then spat it out with a “ptoo, ptoo”: “It’s not tasty at all!”

“Even if it tasted good, you couldn’t swallow it—do you even have a stomach?” Duncan reached out and took the half strip of jerky from Alice’s hand. “I only meant to let you try it, and you really did.”

As he spoke, he glanced at the food on his plate again, now with some worry.

These were the only food he could find on the ship. The jerky felt like thick salted cardboard. The cheese was like loose firewood mixed with sand, and no matter how he handled it, it kept a strange smell. He had tried boiling the jerky in water, roasting it, even pan-frying it, but after all that effort he still could not improve the taste or texture.

The good news was that at least the food had not rotted and would not poison anyone. The bad news was that the power of time still turned these things, which had not decayed, into something he strongly did not recommend putting in a human throat. Duncan had every reason to believe that this cheese was several times older than he was, and if the animals that became the jerky were still alive, they would have seen at least a century of storms and change.

The captain of the Vanished might not have to worry about scurvy, but Duncan still longed for a healthy diet. At the very least, he hoped the food on his plate could be a little younger than he was.

Being the same age would be fine too.

The “Vanished supply plan” and the “land exploration plan” he had thought through yesterday rose in his mind again.

But none of that could be done in a short time.

Duncan sighed and kept cutting the “firewood” on his plate as if he were taking revenge on it. AI, who had been tilting its head on a nearby table for a long time, finally walked over. The bird first looked at its Master, then at the things on the plate: “Crystal ore reserves insufficient?”

Duncan glanced at the pigeon, pinched up some crumbs of cheese that had fallen off, and tossed them to it. AI pecked twice, then suddenly froze in place like a machine that had just crashed…

The bird stayed stiff like that for a full three or four seconds before it suddenly moved again. It flapped its wings wildly and flew to a nearby shelf, squawking in a furious voice: “I would rather starve today, die outside, and jump off from here than eat that again…”

Duncan felt a little hurt, and Goathead, who had finally been quiet for a while on the other side of the table, could not help starting to make squeaking wood-scraping noises.

Before this thing could drill into itself to make fire, Duncan finally nodded: “If you have something to say, just say it.”

“Yes, Captain,” Goathead finally got his chance to talk and became noisy at once. “I have wanted to ask since yesterday. This one you brought… is called ‘AI’, right? Why can I never understand what it says? I thought about it all night yesterday. What does ‘recharge Q-coins’ even mean?”

Duncan raised his eyebrows at once. He had truly not expected Goathead to hold this question in until now. He had actually underestimated this thing’s self-control.

“You don’t need to worry about it. This bird’s way of thinking is very strange,” Duncan said. He did not stop his woodworking, and the knife and fork in his hands kept making the sound of chisels and axes. He casually gave the excuse he had already prepared. “It seems to use a language only it

can fully understand when it talks to people. If you hear it enough, you can roughly guess what it means."

"Is that so?" Goathead fell into thought. "But I keep feeling that there is some kind of logic hidden in its words… as if there is a complete, self-consistent set of knowledge behind that language. You found AI while you were walking in the Spirit Realm, didn't you? Then could it be some projection from the depths of the Abyssal Deep? You know, the deeper you go, the more often information from misaligned times appears as projections. Among them are many lost ages we have never known, and even some fragments of the future. Maybe AI is talking about things from another timeline?"

The cutting in Duncan's hands paused for a moment, so briefly it was almost impossible to see. Then everything went on as usual, and he said in a calm tone: "Then I wish you luck in working out the logic behind AI's language as soon as possible."

Goathead's words might have been random guesses, but the information hidden in them still stirred waves in Duncan's heart.

While he walked in the Spirit Realm, had his soul drawn near to the deeper layers of this world? In those deeper places, would one see more projections from misaligned times? Could those projections even show scenes from different timelines?

When Duncan walked in the Spirit Realm, he had not seen any "scenery from different timelines", but Goathead had not been wrong about one thing —AI really did come from another time and space.

Then… was this pigeon brought into this world by an Earth human named "Zhou Ming", or was it truly, as Goathead said, from the deeper layers of this world?

Chapter 33

This breakfast tasted like wax—and the texture was even worse than wax.

After finishing this less-than-satisfying breakfast, Duncan's mood did not improve at all with his stomach filled. Instead, he grew a bit more restless because some of the things Goathead had mentioned by accident had stirred up a pile of messy guesses.

He looked at the pigeon AI, who was strolling leisurely on a nearby shelf, and felt his wild thoughts grow even more absurd.

He had always thought this pigeon, who kept talking in Earth phrases, was born because he carried the soul of an Earth human. He believed that while he walked in the Spirit Realm, the individual "Zhou Ming" had reacted with the brass spirit compass and thus brought this strange bird AI into being.

But what if… things really were not like that?

If things were really as Goathead had said, and this pigeon was only some kind of phantom that had run out from a "deeper" place and happened to take shape beside him?

Then the Earth phrases AI sometimes blurted out would have nothing to do with Zhou Ming's memories. They would instead be a projection of some piece of history that this world itself had recorded…

The possibilities behind this left Duncan upset and uneasy.

Alice stood up. Her voice cut off Duncan's wandering thoughts: "Do you need me to wash the dishes?"

Duncan looked at Miss Doll in some surprise. She scratched her hair in embarrassment. “I just feel that since I’m already on the ship, I should find something to do. Otherwise I’m just here for food…”

“But you don’t eat at all,” Duncan reminded her. “Still, it’s nice that you want to help. Take the plates to the washroom and have a talk with the sink. If it doesn’t mind, you can wash them.”

After he said this, he did not wait for Alice to answer. He stood up, walked toward the door of the captain’s cabin, and added casually: “I’m going to inspect the deck. Don’t come to bother me if nothing’s wrong.”

The pigeon, still strolling on the shelf, fluttered at once onto Duncan’s shoulder and left the room with him, leaving Alice and Goathead staring at each other across the chart table.

“Is the captain in a bad mood?” Alice asked Goathead carefully after a moment’s hesitation.

Goathead answered in a deep tone: “The captain’s mood is like the weather on the Boundless Sea. Don’t try to guess it. Just accept it.”

Before Goathead could go on, Alice quickly asked again: “Oh right, the captain just told me to talk with the sink… how do I talk with it?”

“That’s simple. You go wash things. If you get splashed all over, that means the sink doesn’t like you. Speaking of which, do you know how to wash dishes? If you don’t, I have some theoretical experience…”

Before Goathead could finish, Alice quickly gathered up the dishes on the table. She rushed toward the door while shouting: “No need, I’ll learn it, thank you, Mr. Goathead, goodbye!”

The captain’s cabin fell quiet at once. Only the dark Goathead remained on the table, his hollow eyes fixed in a gaze at the direction everyone had gone.

After a long time, a sigh came from the chart table: “If only I had legs…”

Then his gaze returned to the enchanted sea chart.

The mist around the Vanished was still slowly thinning, and the steering task the captain had left him still had to be done well.

Under precise control, this huge and “living” ghost ship sensitively adjusted the angles of its sails and continued to sail on the Boundless Sea. Goathead began to hum a sea shanty of unknown age. His rough, hoarse humming, almost like noise, echoed in the captain’s cabin:

“Hoist the sails, hoist the sails, the sailors who left home keep moving forward;

“In wind and waves, in noise and crowds, only a single plank stands between us and death;

“Take in the jib, spread the main sail, loose the ropes, hold the rail! We have already reached the middle of the sea!

“Stay far from the fish, stay far from the fish, sailors must pass beyond those routes where Spawn gather;

“Stay far from the fish, stay far from the fish! We must reach the harbor safe and sound—strong drink and warm hearths lie ahead…”

Duncan walked one round through the supplies storeroom and then another through the kitchen, and only then returned to the midship deck of the Vanished.

No matter how many times he searched, he could not find anything more edible on this ship than jerky and cheese.

The good news was that he did not have to eat maggot-filled biscuits like the sailors of the age of sail on Earth. The bad news was that this ship did not even have maggot-filled biscuits.

He pushed aside his earlier wild thoughts for now and, taking the now quiet AI with him, walked to the edge of the deck.

He gazed at the Boundless Sea and kept thinking:

[No matter what, I have to find a way to resupply the daily necessities on the Vanished… Even if I should not care too much about quality of life on a ghost ship, I still cannot really live like a ghost…]

[Alice might need clothes to change into. There are no dresses on this ship that suit her.]

[I must build contact with the city-states on land as soon as possible… the Vanished has been drifting at sea for too many years. In that time, the city-states on land may have developed to a level even that Goathead could not have predicted. From the things I saw before in that sewer, at least the city-state of Pland is a strong and advanced great city. The revolvers those cultists carried also show how far human society's technology has come…]

[An ancient ghost ship may not be so unbeatable when facing a civilized society that has developed for a century. The Vanished still has some lingering power, but if only that power remains, things will be bad…]

Duncan glanced at AI on his shoulder.

Maybe… after resting and saving his strength today, he should try another walk in the Spirit Realm.

"Coo?"

AI tilted its head. It finally made a sound a normal pigeon should make.

Duncan could not help but smile. Just then, the corner of his eye caught a flash of ripples on the nearby sea.

His attention was drawn by the movement. He instinctively looked out past the ship's rail a few more times and then noticed that something really

seemed to be swimming under the water nearby.

After a brief pause, Duncan suddenly slapped his own forehead.

“Hey! What is wrong with me… This is the sea! Aren’t there fish in the sea?”

This sudden “possibility” lifted Duncan’s mood at once. He knew that setting up contact with the land and arranging a stable supply line for the Vanished could not be done in a day. But could this vast ocean itself not help him a little?

There were fish in the sea—and he was already sick of the jerky and cheese on the ghost ship!

Duncan’s enthusiasm flared up. He remembered that in one of the storerooms under the deck there were heavy fishing rods for sea fishing, and mounts on the rail along the deck edge where the rods could be fixed. As for bait… he wondered if the jerky and cheese would work.

And so, while the cursed Doll washed dishes in the washroom and the talking Goathead focused on steering the ship, the captain of the Vanished busied himself back and forth between the deck and the cabins.

Duncan soon found what he wanted. He carried three heavy fishing rods and the “bait” back to the deck. A bit clumsily, he fixed the rods to the mounts along the rail, baited the hooks, and cast the lines. Then he dragged over an empty barrel to use as a seat while he waited.

In truth, Duncan had no experience with sea fishing. All his fishing experience came from ponds and a small river back in his old hometown. He did not know if this sudden idea would really let him catch any fish, but he was idle anyway, so why not try? What if it worked?

He treated it as a way to rest and recover before his next walk into the Spirit Realm, while also keeping a bit of hope for better meals in the future.

Duncan sat down between the rods. During the long wait, his mood slowly returned to calm.

The sea was fairly calm today. There were quite a few clouds in the sky, but no prophetic vision of a storm.

Duncan sat on the barrel, leaning against a winch used to fasten the ropes. As the ship swayed gently, he narrowed his eyes.

Before he knew it, he slipped into a half-dreaming, half-waking state.

He dreamed that he was walking barefoot on a calm sea. The water was deep blue, and the sunlight was warm.

The familiar and “normal” Sun from his memories hung high in the sky, bright but not scorching.

He heard the sound of splashing water. Following the sound, he saw fish suddenly jump out from the calm surface nearby.

It was a school of small golden fish, each only about the size of a palm. They blew bubbles in the air and waved their tails as if they were swimming in water, slowly circling around Duncan.

These fish that swam through the air drew closer bit by bit. Zhou Ming looked at them with curiosity, at their round bulging eyes, their fine scales, their mouths opening and closing, and the faint ripples, like water waves, that floated behind them.

Zhou Ming suddenly felt that these fish were very beautiful, and also…

Very fragrant.

They must be very, very fragrant.

Chapter 34: Harvest

A sudden crash of waves jolted Duncan awake from his dream.

He snapped his eyes open. The vision he had seen in that half-dream state had already faded, leaving only faint fragments. He only remembered seeing fish swimming in the air, circling around him and looking especially delicious—but what had those fish looked like again?

Fish… could fish really swim in the air?

Duncan blinked. That strange feeling of the Mortal Realm tearing and blending with his dream left him dazed for a moment. He looked at the three fishing rods fixed in the rod rack; none of them showed any sign of a bite. Out on the distant sea, though, the surface had begun to swell, and one wave after another was already slapping against the hull of the Vanished.

Then the waves grew higher. In a way he could see with the naked eye, each new wave grew stronger as they rolled in from afar in an endless rush. The huge hull of the Vanished rocked in the wind and waves, and the roar of the surging water filled his ears.

Duncan looked up at the sky. The weather still seemed fine. There were just more wind and waves, but it should not be enough to turn into some great storm or other extreme phenomenon.

“This might not be the best weather for fishing…”

He muttered to himself, wondering if he should reel in the lines. But just then, out of the corner of his eye, he suddenly saw the tip of one rod bend

sharply!

Sea-fishing line made for strength went taut in an instant. The short, thick rod bent like a bow as if it had hooked some huge creature. It creaked with a harsh sound, and even the wooden rack holding it groaned under the pull. All of this sent Duncan one clear signal:

A fish! A big one!

He instantly dropped the idea of packing up to rest. The passion of a fisherman flared in his chest. In two strides he reached the rod that had hit the jackpot. One hand grabbed it to keep it from tearing free of the rack, and the other began to carefully adjust the tension of the line.

“I knew it! There is no way I was going home empty-handed!”

Duncan talked to himself in excitement as he wrestled with the huge thing on the other end of the line. It was a hard fight. Whatever lay at the end of the line clearly had no intention of surrendering. A tremendous force pulled on the rod; even with Duncan’s strength and the support of the rack, the stalemate still felt dangerously close to breaking.

The wind and waves around the Vanished grew little by little, but for Duncan, this slight rocking was nothing.

He was only getting annoyed by that stubborn “prey” and worried that this hard-won chance to improve their meals might slip away for nothing.

The line was stretched to its limit. The big fish was about to tear free from his hands.

After who knew how long of holding on, Duncan finally steeled himself. A cluster of ghostly emerald flame suddenly spread out from the hand gripping the rod.

The green flame flared, flowing like water. It ran swiftly along the rod and the line. The fire of his spirit form burned all the way down, turning the line into a blazing trail that plunged straight into the sea. A second later, deep down in the water around the Vanished, a hazy outline of emerald fire appeared out of nowhere. In the light of that ghostly flame, a vast shadow took shape in the sea.

That shadow looked like a huge, pulsing mass of flesh. It almost covered the entire stretch of sea for hundreds of meters around the Vanished. Countless dark growths stretched from its edges, constantly changing and multiplying. They writhed and waved through the ocean like thousands of arms, churning the water around the Vanished and driving the rise and fall of the unseen waves.

Duncan heard strange sounds coming from the sea. While he kept up the struggle with his “prey”, he leaned out curiously and glanced around.

He saw nothing, just the rolling waves, not much different from before.

Yet he clearly felt the force pulling on the rod weaken a little.

His prey was running out of strength. That fact brought a bright grin to his face.

He began to reel in hard, tightening the line and dragging his catch out of the water bit by bit…

…

Alice was startled by the roar and howl from outside the cabin. Violent rocking came from under her feet, and all the furnishings in the cabin clattered together in a series of ringing crashes. She grabbed a nearby rail in a quick reflex and barely kept herself from falling. Her face showed shock and doubt as she asked: “What happened?”

The Vanished was shaking as if a great storm raged outside. From deep within this ancient ghost ship came a low, oppressive rumble, as if it were roaring and bellowing, fighting against the terror rising from the Deep Sea, resisting some huge beast that was trying to swallow it whole.

Everything in the cabin was rattling and ringing. At first, Alice thought it was all just from the ship's shaking. But soon she realized many of the noisy objects were actually clattering in place—making sounds as they talked to each other. Alice could not understand this language that only the Vanished itself could comprehend.

She only knew that something outside had probably gone wrong.

The doll decided to go up to the deck and take a look—she stumbled out of the cabin, one hand on the wall to keep from falling as she ran toward the deck.

After almost tripping several times over whipping ropes and barrels rolling about, she finally reached the top of the stairs. She pushed open the wooden door that kept swinging in the wind and saw monstrous waves rising on the Boundless Sea.

The sky was black as ink. Ominous, heavy clouds had almost clumped into solid masses, pressing low over the sea. Wall-like waves rolled and surged under the dark clouds, rising and falling around the Vanished as if to encircle it.

Alice had never seen such a sight before. She did not know if this was normal at sea, but she did know she had to find the captain now.

She looked around the deck and, almost without effort, spotted Captain Duncan standing at the edge.

…

The wind and waves around him were a bit annoying, but to Duncan, who was about to succeed, they were only trivial distractions. From the feedback of both the line and the green flame, he could clearly feel that his prey had stopped resisting. The huge creature was being dragged out of the water bit by bit.

“Come on up!”

He shouted in delight and gave the rod one last hard pull.

A big fish burst out of the sea—truly big, almost half his own height.

For a brief instant, Duncan locked eyes with the fish hanging in midair.

“…Pretty ugly.”

That was his first thought.

It really was a very, very ugly fish. Its pitch-black body looked covered with some kind of overgrown, lumpy growths. Weird gray-white patterns sprawled messily along its fins. Many bone-like spines jutted from its head, and a pair of pale, empty eyes under those spines stared straight at Duncan.

Duncan felt very uneasy. He had the strange sense that the fish was staring at him with ill intent.

But the next second, he saw the fish suddenly convulse. For some reason, the eyes that had been staring at him burst apart out of nowhere, and blood streamed out at once.

The fish fell heavily onto the deck and thrashed and twisted like it had been shocked by lightning. In just a few seconds it went still. Blood seeped from its mouth and its burst eyes, dripping onto the deck bit by bit.

Duncan watched in surprise as the hideous fish quickly lost all life at his feet. He vaguely recalled something he had read in books: most fish from the Deep Sea really were very ugly, and because they lived under heavy

pressure for so long, when they were pulled up to the surface their blood vessels could burst from the change, even killing them quickly because of it. So the fish in this world were like that too?

While he was still spacing out, another series of sharp thuds suddenly came from nearby.

Duncan looked over in curiosity and saw several smaller “strange fish” falling onto the deck one after another.

They looked much like the half-man-high monster fish, but were only about half a meter long. And just like the big one, by the time Duncan’s gaze fell on them, they were already bleeding heavily all over and soon lay at death’s door.

Duncan stood there, a bit stunned, and only after a long moment did he react: “Is this like the Calabash Brothers saving Grandpa, coming one after another in a line?”

…

Alice gripped the nearby rail tightly, nervously watching the savage fight not far away, a scene enough to drive an ordinary person mad.

She saw Captain Duncan standing at the edge of the deck, ghost-green flames roaring from his body. He stood like a burning giant facing the sea. Three hooked chains stretched out from the deck at his feet, and terrible flames burned along one of them.

She saw a vast shadow suddenly appear in the Boundless Sea. Then a tentacle, almost thicker than the mainmast of the Vanished, rose from the water. Countless eyes full of malice opened along its surface, and numberless sharp teeth ground and chewed between those eyes, as if ready to bite the entire ship into pieces in the next instant.

Alice almost cried out. She wanted to warn the captain to dodge, to rush in and help, but before she could move, the tentacle crashed down toward him.

She saw Captain Duncan lift his head. In the blaze of the flames, his face actually showed the joy of a bountiful harvest—he was staring at the countless eyes on the tentacle, and the countless eyes on the tentacle were staring back at him.

The next second, all the eyes on the tentacle burst apart at once. Hundreds of sharp teeth let out a shrill, agonized screech. Then the tentacle simply broke off in midair—as if some huge body hidden beneath the surface had cut off its own limb on purpose and thrown the badly wounded end onto the deck.

The tentacle crashed down. Foul, sticky flesh spilled from the severed end, splattering all over and landing at the captain’s feet.

Chapter 35: Calm and Normal

The sea grew calm.

Alice saw the tentacle lying on the deck and pieces of flesh filled with some great power scattered at the captain's feet. Life quickly drained out of that flesh. At the same time, the huge thing lurking beneath the water around the Vanished began to dive away faster. After paying one tentacle as the "price", it left the waters around the Vanished in a rush, almost as if it were fleeing in panic.

As that vast shadow sank back into the Deep Sea, the ocean returned to calm with a speed that was shocking. The dark clouds in the sky, black as ink, vanished completely along with it.

…Maybe they had not been clouds at all.

Alice looked up at the sky. She still remembered what those clouds had looked like. Thinking back to their outline as they faded, she finally faintly matched them with the shadow that had been under the water around the ship.

The thick clouds above had looked like a patch of shadow—the shadow cast onto the sky by some enormous creature in the sea.

The crackle of burning flames came from the edge of the deck, snapping Alice out of her daze. She quickly looked toward the captain and saw that he had already returned to his usual appearance. The tall man wore a cheerful smile. He had already noticed Alice standing not far away and waved for the doll to come over.

When Alice walked up to him, Duncan nudged the big fish on the deck with his boot and said in a slightly proud tone: “Look, I caught a big fish!”

“A b-big fish?” Alice’s expression went blank. She stared at the lump of flesh by Duncan’s feet. Among the twisted, rolling meat, countless eyes, split open in the flesh, still half-open and half-closed, gazed up at the sky, while jagged teeth between the eyes glinted with a metallic cold light.

As Duncan’s boot nudged it, about half the eyes on the severed tentacle suddenly blinked, then all closed at once.

“Yeah, a big fish,” Duncan said happily. “Look, it took quite a bit of effort to haul this thing up here.”

Even though she was only a doll, Alice still felt as if some “muscle” at the corner of her eye twitched for a moment. She opened her mouth to speak, but did not know where to even start correcting him.

She looked at the “fish” at Duncan’s feet.

A hideous big fish lay there—black and dull, with pitted, uneven skin. Strange gray-white markings spread around the fins. Bony spines jutted from its head, and a pair of lifeless fish eyes met her gaze.

There were also many “small fish” scattered across the deck nearby.

Alice suddenly lost all expression and words. She stared wide-eyed at the scene before her, at the “fish” lying on the deck, at these things that, a second ago, had not been “fish” at all.

The doll, lacking any real life experience, did not yet understand what “questioning one’s life” meant. But in that moment, she truly began to doubt everything. She even wondered if she was dreaming—where had the tentacle and all those chunks of flesh gone?

Maybe her moment of blankness was too obvious, because Duncan immediately noticed Alice's odd reaction. He raised an eyebrow and looked at the doll: "What is it? Is something wrong?"

"I…" Alice opened her mouth, but just as she was about to correct him, the rules Goathead had told her earlier suddenly surfaced in her mind.

On the Vanished, Captain Duncan was absolute authority. His words were absolute "fact"—if the Mortal Realm disagreed with what Captain Duncan said, then the captain's judgment was the one that counted.

"Nothing is wrong!" Alice snapped back to herself and blurted out quickly. Then, as if to cover how tense she sounded, she hurriedly changed the subject: "By the way, Captain, that storm just now was really scary…"

"Storm? You mean those waves?" Duncan looked at the doll in puzzlement. "Those waves were not small, but they were far from a real storm… Then again, you have never seen a true storm."

Alice said: "…You are right."

If Captain Duncan called that storm that had almost covered the whole sea "waves", then they were waves. If Captain Duncan thought what he had dragged onto the deck were "fish", then these things were fish.

"…I feel like you are a bit tense. Are you really all right?" Duncan still picked up on something off in Alice's tone. He looked at his "Crewman One" with some concern. "Are you seasick? Can you even get seasick?"

"I am fine. It was just that the ship was shaking so hard just now, I…" Alice looked at the captain's concerned face, unsure whether she should feel comforted or even more afraid. She could only stiffly change the subject: "Right, these… 'fish' you caught—what are you going to do with them?"

"Do you even need to ask?" Duncan laughed at once. "Of course we are going to eat them!"

Alice’s expression froze at once: “…Eat them?”

“What else? Have you not noticed how boring the food stores on the Vanished are?” Duncan was clearly in a very good mood. “I plan to cut up the big one, stew part of it and roast part of it. These few smaller ones, we will salt and dry into fish jerky…”

He happily talked through his plan, but even though he sounded confident, he was actually not sure he could pull it off. His cooking skills were only average. He had no experience dealing with such a huge sea fish, and as for making dried fish, he had only some theoretical knowledge and no practice at all.

But how would he know if he did not at least try?

The only problem… was not to poison their stomachs.

Even in the joy of such a rich haul, Duncan still kept some reason. He looked down at the big fish by his feet with care, wondering whether this gift from nature might be poisonous.

The safest way was to find some unlucky soul to taste it first.

He first thought of Goathead in the captain’s cabin, then ruled that option out at once. Then he glanced at the cursed Doll across from him—but that doll would not work either.

Alice did not even have a stomach.

At last, he looked at the pigeon on his shoulder.

The pigeon tilted its head and looked back at him.

No matter how you looked at her, AI did not seem like a normal creature. But if he had to find some living being with flesh and blood on this ship, it seemed only this pigeon was left…

A moment later, Duncan left the deck with his “harvest”. Lunchtime was close, and he could not wait to improve the meals on the Vanished.

Alice stood there in a daze for a while, then walked to the door of the captain’s cabin.

She had not planned to seek out Goathead. Ever since she had seen how terribly chatty this “First Mate” could be last time, she had developed a deep awe of the entire captain’s cabin.

If she could help it, she never wanted to step through that door on her own.

But what had happened today was just too strange. She felt it was still necessary to consult the experienced Mr. Goathead and see whether this was actually something normal on the Vanished.

She was not breaking any crew member rules. She was only asking about the situation. That should not count as a taboo.

After hesitating for a good ten seconds, Alice finally worked up her courage and pulled open the door to the captain’s cabin.

The next second, she stared in shock. Goathead had already turned to face the doorway and was staring fixedly in her direction—as if he had been waiting for her to come.

“What happened out there?” Goathead spoke, unusually brief and to the point.

Alice sensed that something was off from this uncharacteristic behavior. She quickly turned to shut the door behind her, then walked to the chart table and told him everything she had seen.

When she finished speaking, Goathead fell into an unusually long silence—for nearly a full minute, he did not say a single word.

The carved wooden Goathead could not change expression, but Alice could plainly feel that… things seemed to have gone a bit beyond this “First Mate’s” understanding.

Alice suddenly grew nervous and leaned forward without thinking: “So this is not something that normally happens on the Vanished? Has the captain really…”

“The Vanished is perfectly normal,” Goathead finally snapped out of his silence and answered quickly, cutting off Alice’s words as if to plug some gap at once. “Listen. The Vanished is perfectly normal. It is always normal, and the great Captain Duncan is exactly as he has always been!”

“Then… it was just how you reacted…”

“Things are a bit beyond what I expected—but that is only because my imagination and understanding are lacking,” Goathead’s words became smooth again as he slowly recovered from his shock. His mood clearly rose, and even his tone grew passionate and excited. “Yes, the great Captain Duncan—he should be even greater and stronger! There is nothing abnormal, Miss Alice. Listen, everything on the Vanished is as it should be! Let the captain do whatever he thinks is right. Do not keep talking about this… All you need to do from today on is remember this fact:”

“There are fish in the Vanished’s galley, and fish are delicious ingredients.”

Chapter 36: At the Turn of Day and Night

Turning such a huge fish into lunch was not easy at all.

It took skill, and it was hard physical work too.

Luckily, Duncan was driven by a fisherman’s sense of duty and a strong desire to improve their meals, so he tackled today’s catch with plenty of energy.

He worked in the galley for a long time. At last he managed to pry off the bony spines on the ugly monster’s head and clumsily cut its plump body into several pieces. There was hardly any meat on the head, so he tossed it aside for now. The belly and back, though, had some very good cuts, perfect for turning into ingredients aboard the Vanished.

It looked a little odd for a dignified captain to be busy in the kitchen himself, but Duncan actually enjoyed it. He only wondered what those ordinary people who feared the Vanished like a calamity would think if they saw this scene. Would they be shocked that the dreaded ghost captain also had such a down?to?earth, domestic side, or would they first praise Duncan’s excellent fishing skills?

He thought of this while he was cutting up the strange fish. In his good mood, he could not help but laugh. He wondered if, one day, he might actually invite some people aboard as guests. The Vanished would not always be another word for disaster. He did not plan to stay a cold?blooded,

heartless ghost captain forever. Once he understood this world better, he fully intended to connect with modern civilized society.

When that day came, he would serve those guests fish.

After the rough but simple butchering, Duncan put most of the fish into a wooden barrel lined with sea salt, then rolled the heavy barrel into a storage room at the back of the galley. He left the smaller pieces for later. He planned to salt them and hang them to dry on the deck. If all went well, the sea breeze would turn them into dried salted fish.

It was a pity he had not found any strong liquor on the ship, or he would have had a few more ways to cure the fish.

Having fresh fish every day was great, of course, but Duncan knew fishing always depended on luck. Today’s haul was impressive, but the future might not be so kind, so he had to think about how to process and store the extra food.

After all, even though the dried meat and cheese in the stores of the Vanished showed no signs of decay, he had no idea if that was because the Vanished itself was special, or because those “dried meats” and “cheeses” were some kind of Anomaly. Letting hard?won fish rot would be a real shame.

At the very least, salted dried fish would be better than century?old salted meat, if only for a change of taste.

Duncan kept the freshest, best?looking cuts and threw them into the pot with some of the dried meat. In this case, the dried meat only served as seasoning.

It was a wasteful way to cook. Any real chef who saw what Duncan was doing would probably have their blood pressure shoot through the roof. The best use for such tender fish would have been to make a raw fish dish, and

the second best would be to pan?fry or grill it lightly. Duncan knew that very well, but he chose this method to be safe.

He did not dare eat some unknown creature from the sea raw. In theory, sea fish did not carry parasites harmful to people, and as this “ghost captain” he probably did not need to fear ordinary poisons anyway, but what if he was wrong?

Compared to that, stewing was the most reliable way to deal with an unfamiliar ingredient.

He would try it this way first. If he confirmed the fish was really edible, then he would think about other recipes.

By the time he finished, it was almost late afternoon, and his very late “lunch” was finally ready.

He ladled out a bowl of fish soup. The rich smell made his mouth water, but before he ate, he carefully speared a piece of fish, blew on it to cool it, and set it down in front of the pigeon, AI.

A normal pigeon did not eat meat, of course, but AI could not really be called a normal pigeon.

Duncan wanted to satisfy his curiosity. On the Vanished, there were far too many things he needed to test.

As for what he would do if this Anomaly pigeon really got poisoned after eating the fish… Duncan already had a plan.

First, he had already prepared the ingredient as carefully as he could, so letting the pigeon try it was more of a formality. Second, if anything really went wrong with AI, he could use the green flame at once to pull her entirely into a spirit form state. He had already tested this before. In spirit form, AI reacted the same way as the brass spirit compass. She was like an “object” controlled by the fire of spirit form. He could even break down and

reassemble spirit form AI and teleport her to any spot near him. Under those conditions, ordinary toxins definitely would not work on her.

AI tilted her head as she watched Duncan. After she realized the piece of fish was for her, she first pecked at the tabletop beside it with her beak. Her eyes wandered between Duncan and the ceiling as she asked: “You sure this melon’s ripe?”

Duncan said: “Just say if you’re going to eat it or not.”

AI flapped her wings and copied his tone: “Just say if you’re going to eat it or not!”

Only then did she lower her head and peck at the cooled fish. At a shocking speed, she finished off a piece of food that clearly was not meant for a pigeon!

After she finished, AI stretched her neck hard, then strutted proudly across the table. She seemed in a very good mood. After circling once, she came back in front of Duncan and squawked loudly: “So tasty! So tasty!”

Duncan stared at the pigeon, dumbfounded. Somehow a thought popped into his head: this thing now combined “pigeon, ‘so tasty,’ and broken record” all in one!

With all three key traits in place, it was practically the pride of Humans on Earth. If you filled out one of those free?form nine?square meme charts, this thing might even qualify as an Earthling…

After a while longer, Duncan confirmed that the pigeon showed no Anomalous reaction, and finally he relaxed completely.

So the captain of the Vanished and his pet hid in the kitchen, feasting away.

The fish really was delicious, just like what Duncan had seen in his dream.

…

The setting sun slowly sank toward the high walls at the edge of the city. The tall chimneys, pipes, and towers of the city?state of Pland were bathed bit by bit in pale golden light.

From the high ground in the city center, where the Storm Cathedral stood, came the deep tolling of the Great Bell. At the same time, the shrill whistle of steam gushing from relief valves rose into the air. A huge plume of white vapor burst from the tops of the side towers of the Cathedral, spreading like cloud and mist over the sky above the hill, refracting the golden sunlight from the sea.

This was the signal of the turning of day and night. It was a reminder that the power of the Sun was about to fade quickly, and that the World’s Wound would soon take the dominant place in the sky.

After that, the order of the mortal world would go from solid to unstable, and the influence from the world’s deep layers would grow stronger and stronger as the veil of night descended. This process would continue until the Sun rose again the next day.

Under the veil of night, cautious people chose to stay at home. Those who had no choice but to go out tried their best to stay where the lights were bright. Gas lamps that had received the divine blessing of the Clerics could drive away the malice in the veil of night as much as possible.

Even so, this was at least a prosperous and stable great city?state. Under the protection of the holy Storm Cathedral, even the deepest influences of the world’s deep layers were held down below a safe limit. The Anomalies that appeared in the city once in a while were only small problems. Ordinary citizens knew how to keep their homes safe, and at night the Church Guardians took over the Constables’ duties, keeping order in the city after nightfall.

Yet just as even the brightest streetlamp could not banish every Shadow, even right under the noses of the Church Guardians there were always fools who longed for darkness and upheaval. They feared and hated the current order of the world and, in their frenzy, yearned for some “glorious age” that even they had never seen.

Fortunately, in a city?state where the forces of order held the upper hand, these subversives could only curl up in the Shadows most of the time.

At the edge of the city?state, deep inside a sealed sewer entrance, several figures in black robes huddled in the corner of a small room.

This had once been a rest room for sewer maintenance workers, but it had been forgotten as the city’s layout changed. This neglected corner had become a refuge for cultists on the run. A dim Oil lamp hung on the wall. Its flickering light fell on several gloomy faces, full of fear and simmering hatred.

A man of about thirty lay on a bed made of ragged cloth on the floor. His teeth were clenched, his face pale, and his breathing weak and uneven. The others sat near him. One of them cursed under his breath: “Those damned Church jackals…”

“We lost so many of our brothers, and even the Envoy died in the ritual…” another said hoarsely. “How could such a holy ritual suddenly lose control…”

“That sacrificial victim… It was clearly because of that sacrificial victim. He was obviously a servant of the Heretics…”

“Listen,” one of the robed figures suddenly said. He tilted his head in the posture of the Listening Rite, then pointed upward. “That’s the dusk Bell and the whistles.”

“…nightfall is coming,” the first robed man, the one who had been cursing, said in a low voice. Uneasily, he looked at the “brother” lying on the floor in such a terrible state. “Damn it… I hope he can make it through this night…”

Chapter 37: The Cycle of Life and Death

The dusk Bell and the steam whistles that marked the change of day and night echoed faintly through the deep, damp ramps and shafts. In the cramped darkness of the sewers, that signal of the approaching veil of night made the cultists hiding in the abandoned rest room even more depressed.

One of them was seriously ill, with no clear cause. Now he was about to die—die here, in this dimly lit underground world.

“He’s still alive… for now,” one cultist said hesitantly. He glanced at the “brother” lying on the floor and saw that the man’s eyes were half?open, the eyeballs slowly rolling in their sockets. The poor fellow could still hear what was happening around him, but he no longer had the strength to open his eyes.

“He’s only alive for now,” another cultist said in a low voice. “The dusk Bell has already rung. He cannot die in this room. The Lord’s protection will grant him rest in the darkness.”

The man on the makeshift bed twitched his fingers twice. He clearly understood his situation. He did not want to die like this, but death had already sunk its teeth into his shadow. From the sound of it, his dear “brethren of the Sun” were already thinking about removing this “hidden danger” from their Sanctuary World before true death arrived.

An unbearably heavy silence filled the room. The dying man’s faint breathing sounded loud in the stillness. After an unknown stretch of dead

quiet, the black?robed man who had cursed the Storm Church finally broke the silence: “Wait a little longer. At least… a person doesn’t change the instant he breathes his last.”

“…Then we’ll wait a bit more,” the black?robed cultist with the low voice said, softening slightly. He glanced at the man who was still struggling to breathe, then could not help muttering, “But why did he suddenly fall ill? Are you sure this is just an ordinary sickness?”

“I know him… He runs a failing antique shop in the Lower City, the kind where everything on the shelves is fake,” said another cultist who had barely spoken before. “He was already sick. His health was never good. Maybe staying in the sewers too long, and the fright from earlier, made his condition worse.”

Hearing this explanation, the low?voiced cultist finally relaxed a little. He was not a high?ranking priest, but he had followed the Sun for many years and, by now, could be considered an “expert” who knew quite a bit about occult studies. He knew very well how many long?lasting, hidden dangers could remain after a failed sacrificial rite, and any believer who had taken part in that rite might become a “carrier” of those hidden threats. This man who had suddenly fallen into extreme weakness… could very well be one such carrier.

If it were not for the rule that “all children of the Sun are as brothers,” and for the fact that several soft?hearted cultists were watching, he would long ago have thrown this unlucky fellow out into the endless darkness outside.

After a long silence, the black?robed cultist suddenly moved. He took a pale golden charm amulet from his robe and tucked it into the chest of the dying “brother.”

“What are you doing…” one of the cultists beside him asked curiously.

“This sacred charm amulet cost me dearly. I traded a great deal to get it from the Envoy,” he said in a low, earnest voice. “May the Lord’s grace protect our brother. The light of the Sun may keep him from further corruption in the darkness.”

The two cultists beside him did not doubt him at all and looked at this Church senior, who had “given away” his charm amulet, with admiration. They pressed their fists to their brows and murmured devoutly: “All children of the Sun are as brothers…”

The low?voiced robed man also pressed his fist to his brow and whispered after them: “All children of the Sun are as brothers.”

…

After the Sun sank completely below the horizon, the starless, moonless sky appeared once more before Duncan. The Pale Rift stretched across the heavens, its cold light shining down on the Boundless Sea and on the Vanished sailing upon it.

Duncan stood near the stern deck. He pulled his gaze back from the sky and let out a small sigh.

No matter how many times he looked, he would never see stars in that pale, cold glow, because they simply were not there.

But compared to the last time he saw this starless night, his mood was much better now.

On one hand, he had already accepted the many strange things about this world and was actively adapting to his new life. On the other hand, today’s fish had truly been excellent.

He was an optimist. Any tiny improvement in life was enough to make him happy—and the gifts of nature had turned out to be more plentiful than he had imagined.

If things kept going at this pace, even if he could not build stable contact with the lands on shore for a while, he could at least improve the living conditions on this ship.

Lost in these wandering thoughts, he turned his head to look at the pigeon standing on his shoulder and joked: “Tell me… would it be easier if I just did what a pirate captain is supposed to do? Like find a busy sea route and rob whoever passes by…”

The pigeon tilted her head, her two eyes looking in who?knew?what directions. “Does that sound right, does that sound right, does that sound right…” she muttered.

“True, it doesn’t really fit my personality,” Duncan said with a laugh. “And it’s easy to say, but to rob people you first have to find a sea route where merchant ships actually pass.”

The vast sea around them was empty. He had no idea how far the Vanished had drifted from civilized waters. Ever since the collision with the ship that had been carrying Anomaly 099, he had not seen another vessel on the horizon. Even if he wanted to become a robber, he would not know where to find victims.

Just then, a voice came from the side and interrupted his wandering thoughts: “Captain, are we going to rob someone?”

Duncan followed the sound and saw Alice sitting on a high plank nearby, looking this way with curiosity.

Under the glow of the Pale Scar in the sky, the Doll in her court dress sat high on the ghost ship. Her mercury?like long hair shone with a cold luster in the night. She sat with proper poise, curiosity in her eyes. The whole scene looked like a classical, mysterious painting.

For a moment, Duncan was a little taken aback. After all the chaotic “Mortal Realm chores” they had gone through lately, he had almost forgotten the elegant, mysterious impression this Miss Doll had given him when she first lay in that wooden crate. Seeing Alice so quiet now actually left him a little stunned.

Alice had no idea what the captain was thinking. She simply asked again with curiosity: “Captain, are we going to rob someone?”

That line did quite a bit of damage to her image.

Duncan looked at the Doll, half amused, half helpless, and asked: “Do you like robbing people?”

“No,” Alice shook her head. “It doesn’t sound very fun.”

“But I ‘robbed’ you onto this ship,” Duncan reminded her with a smile.

“…That’s true,” Alice thought for a moment and nodded, then asked again right away: “So are we going to rob someone now?”

“No,” Duncan waved his hand and walked unhurriedly toward his captain’s cabin. “I also think robbing is pretty boring. Compared to that, a walk is a much better after?dinner exercise.”

Duncan returned to the captain’s cabin. After briefly telling Goathead to take the helm, he went into his bedroom as he had last time and closed the door.

He had decided to make his second walk into the Spirit Realm tonight.

But unlike last time, this time he would test this ability through the pigeon, AI.

A wisp of ghostly green flame danced at Duncan’s fingertips. As it flared, the pigeon that had been pacing on the table vanished in an instant and then reappeared on his shoulder.

Feeling the faint, subtle link between himself and AI, Duncan slowly calmed his mind. He recalled the “feeling” he had when he activated the brass spirit compass last time, and began to use the fire of spirit form in his hand to reach out to AI—

The invisible green fire turned into a thin line that wrapped around AI’s wings. In the next second, the White Dove was suddenly engulfed in flame!

As the flames burned, the White Dove’s feathers turned ethereal. The rising green flame seemed to reshape her flesh and bones. AI spread her wings within the fire, and the brass spirit compass hanging at her chest snapped open. The dial, carved with countless occult studies runes, glimmered faintly, and the pointer at its center spun wildly before snapping to a stop, pointing straight into the distance.

The surrounding scene broke apart and scattered. The familiar dark space appeared before Duncan’s eyes, followed by the familiar streams of light and countless spark?like “lamps.”

Following the feeling in his heart, Duncan looked toward those lights, searching for the next suitable “target” to contact.

Suddenly, one cluster of light drew his attention.

He did not know if this was what Goathead always called “Captain Duncan’s intuition,” but he chose to follow this feeling. Whoever was behind that light, they were now fated to cross paths with Captain Duncan.

…

In the abandoned sewers at the edge of the city?state of Pland, the Suntists who had narrowly escaped the Church Guardians sat in wordless silence.

The world above had already fallen into deep night. Down here, only one weak light protected the abandoned room.

Even the most brutal, inhuman cultist felt nervous and afraid as the darkness drew closer.

On the rag bed beside them, the dying man was about to breathe his last.

As his breathing grew lower and more labored, several pairs of eyes turned to the dying man at the same time.

They stared hard at the “brother” on the floor. Every one of them knew the man would not survive the night.

Under the gaze of those eyes, the man’s chest rose and fell one last time. He breathed out the final breath of his life.

“May the Sun continue to shine on your soul in the dark,” the low?voiced black?robed cultist said slowly. Then he waved his hand. “Take him…”

The next second, his words stuck in his throat.

Before his eyes, the body with its eyes tightly shut began to breathe again.

Chapter 38

Chapter 38. Offline

The corpse was breathing. It was as if it had walked along the edge of the land of death and then turned back to the Mortal Realm.

The black-robed cultists in the room stared blankly at this scene. Some of them had not even realized that the man in front of them had already “died” once. The moment when life turned to death had been so short that anyone not watching closely could hardly notice it. They only felt that the breath of their dying “companion” had suddenly become steady and strong for some reason, which was very strange.

The next second, the man lying on the ground opened his eyes.

He seemed to have stayed in darkness for too long. Even the dim oil lamp in the room felt harsh to him. He blinked to get used to the light. Then his eyeballs slowly turned, as if he had only just noticed the three black-robed figures gathered around him.

“Thank the Lord for His protection!” A younger black-robed cultist finally reacted and could not help shouting in excitement. “You made it through! I thought you were going to…”

“Wait! No! Step back!” The deep-voiced cultist suddenly realized something. He threw out an arm to block the others and stared hard at the man who had just woken up, his gaze sharp and wary as he backed away. His voice carried a threat as he said: “His breathing stopped completely just now. I definitely did not see wrong… something is not right!”

Duncan finally adapted to his surroundings. The ringing in his ears slowly faded from his mind. He saw the figures gathered around him, and his first thought was: [Why is it still these people when I open my eyes? Why am I still in the sewer?]

Walking the Spirit Realm should have been random. When he chose his target, he had just followed his intuition and tapped at random. Yet somehow, both times he opened his eyes, he ended up in the middle of these cultists. What kind of twisted fate was this?

Then, from their reactions, he noticed that something was wrong, and a second later he became aware of the black robe on his own body.

Duncan stayed silent for two seconds. Then understanding dawned in his heart.

Last time, he had been the sacrificial victim offered up by the cultists in a sacrificial rite. He had closed his eyes as a victim and opened them again… now as a “cultist”.

He really did have a special connection with this group.

“…Something is not right!”

At that moment, a deep, hostile voice cut through the confusion in Duncan’s newly “awakened” mind. He followed the sound and met a cold, wary stare.

The owner of that stare was fixing a cold, divine gaze on him. Beside him, the other two black-robed cultists finally reacted as well. They backed away and took up guarded stances.

Duncan froze for a moment and suddenly realized that, just like last time, he had possessed a corpse.

He had just sat up like a zombie in front of these cultists’ eyes.

Once he understood the situation, their nervous reactions made perfect sense. Duncan's mind started racing. He could still feel the numbness and sluggishness lingering in this body. It had not fully faded. Moving was difficult. Doing anything under the noses of several cultists would not be easy. For now, he had to calm them down somehow—

And while he was quickly thinking of a way out, scattered, blurry fragments of memory suddenly floated up in his mind.

In those broken memories, he "remembered" many experiences that did not belong to him. He remembered "himself" hiding in the sewers. He remembered "himself" offering all the money from home to the envoy of the Sun. He remembered "himself" joining those dark, mad, bloody, sinful rituals to cure his illness, drinking the blood of innocent people in exchange for "the Sun's divine blessing"…

At the end of that string of jumbled memories, he "saw" the scene of the sacrificial rite. He saw many people in black robes like his own standing beside a high platform. A young sacrificial victim was pushed up onto it. The young sacrificial victim wore a stiff, twisted expression that threw the entire ritual into chaos…

He saw "the envoy of the Sun" have his heart ripped out in the sacrificial rite. Everyone around the altar fell into madness. cultists began slaughtering each other. Surging flames poured out of the Sun totem. Angry roars and hollow whispers filled the gathering place. The original master of this body and the last few surviving cultists fled in a panic…

Duncan did not know how long he stayed dazed. Perhaps it had only been a moment. The flood of unfamiliar memories in his mind slowly calmed again. A pitiful and hateful life broke apart into pale fragments, lying in his heart like something to be read—like some kind of "nourishment".

These were the memories of this body's original master. There was not much left, but the source was beyond doubt.

Duncan blinked. This was something that had not happened during his last "Spirit Realm walk".

Last time, he had gained no memories from the corpse he possessed. The brain of that "sacrificial victim" had been nothing but a blank… so why had things changed this time?

Was it because the body he had taken over was still "fresh"? Or was it because the pigeon AI had strengthened the power of the brass spirit compass?

Duncan slowly sat up from the floor. No matter what caused this change, now was not the time to stare into space. Those tightly strung cultists had clearly sensed that this "true resurrection" was not right.

As Duncan moved, the three cultists immediately stepped back half a pace. The deep-voiced man broke the silence, one hand pressed to his belt: "Don't move yet—tell me, what is your name?"

"…Ron," Duncan said after a brief search through his new memories. The name came out naturally. "Ron Strain."

"He is called Ron." The young black-robed cultist opposite him quickly lowered his voice and whispered to the deep-voiced man who seemed to be their leader.

But the deep-voiced man did not relax at all. He still stared hard at Duncan. Then he began to chant in a strange rhythm: "In the name of the Sun, may our Lord's light shine on all. In the name of the Sun, may our Lord's divine blessing descend!"

Hearing the cultist across from him suddenly start raving, Duncan was stunned for a second. Then he felt a burning heat in his chest. He

instinctively reached under his clothes and pulled out the thing heating up there. It was a golden Sun charm amulet—waves of strange heat were rising from its surface!

The next second, the charm amulet suddenly burst into fierce flames. The fire seemed full of malice and lunged straight toward Duncan's heart!

"The Lord's glory is devouring him!" The cultist who had just finished the prayer reacted at once when he saw this. He drew the short sword at his waist and shouted: "His soul has been replaced! Kill this heretic filth!"

The other two cultists were a bit slower to react, but they still moved a heartbeat later. A moment ago they had thought Duncan was their "companion". Now they drew their short swords and daggers without hesitation, charging at him with murderous intent while shouting: "Kill him!!"

Duncan gripped the Sun charm amulet now burning fiercely in his hand and watched the three figures rush toward him. The next second, another shadow suddenly appeared at the edge of his vision.

A bird wreathed all over in pale green flames, like a wraith-like undead creature, tore through the air. Wrapped in a stream of icy fire, it swept over the ceiling. It let out a strange, shrill screech, and with every beat of its wings it scattered invisible ash and feather fragments.

Of course the three cultists had their attention stolen by this "undead bird". They looked up without thinking and glanced at AI, who had taken on spirit form.

In the next moment, all their movements slowed. Their connection to the Mortal Realm suddenly seemed distant and dull. The three black-robed figures looked like they were being played frame by frame in midair, leaving overlapping afterimages behind them. Their bodies drifted

downward in a slow, almost comical way and finally froze less than two meters in front of Duncan.

Terror filled their eyes as they watched the undead bird circle the ceiling once, then land on the shoulder of the black-robed “companion” opposite them. They saw the Sun charm amulet in the man’s hand still burning fiercely, but the next second, the flames turned a dim green, becoming the same fire that burned on the undead bird.

Duncan squeezed the Sun charm amulet in his hand. Tendrils of green spirit-form fire coiled around its surface. The flames shooting out of the charm amulet curved halfway around in front of him, then settled down like a tame pet, curling slowly around his arm in a friendly way.

Holding the Sun charm amulet that had been completely taken over and changed, he walked unhurriedly up to the three cultists. Looking into their horrified eyes, he spoke with a hint of regret in his voice: “It would have been so much better if you had just pretended you knew nothing.”

The next second, the figures of the three cultists flickered violently in midair and then vanished.

The skeletal-looking undead bird wrapped in green flames hopped twice on Duncan’s shoulder. With the crackling sound of burning fire, it let out a sharp, hoarse cry: “Oh no, the page is gone. Try refreshing?”

Chapter 39

Chapter 39. The Captain Set Foot on Land

When the pigeon said that, both its words and its tone were the same as always—silly, joking, and completely unserious.

But now it was an undead bird burning with ghostly flames. Semi-transparent flesh wrapped bones and tendons filled with fire. Its call was mixed with crackling bursts, like the wails of wronged souls leaking out when the gates of the underworld opened.

As it turned out, the distance between creepy and clownish was often not that great.

The spirit-form fire curling around Duncan still burned. He watched with his own eyes as the three cultists vanished in front of him, but he was not sure of the principle behind it.

He only knew that this was AI's ability.

A few seconds later, after he confirmed that the three cultists truly were not coming back, he tilted his head a little and asked the pigeon on his shoulder: "…Where did you send them?"

AI flapped its wings and used its beak to preen its now semi-transparent feathers. It thought for a moment before suddenly blurting out: "Sent back into the Shadows!"

Duncan frowned. Lately he had started to learn how to understand the real meaning behind AI's words: "…You mean you banished them into some

kind of… parallel space? Or turned them into something that can’t be touched?”

The pigeon lifted its head and stared at Duncan with its wandering eyes: “Coo, coo!”

Now it was pretending to be a real pigeon again.

But Duncan believed he had already grasped the truth. He pressed a finger lightly on AI’s head, then once again looked around this dimly lit “Sanctuary World”.

Under the shaking light of the oil lamp, everything in the small room was clear. The believers of the Sun who had once hidden here had vanished completely from this world. Now, the only ones standing here were a ghost ship captain who had descended by taking over a cultist’s corpse—and his pigeon.

Yet somehow, Duncan had a feeling. He felt as if the three cultists were still here, right beside him, trapped in this room, squeezed into some gap in a dimension that no method could detect or touch.

He could even “feel” those cultists shouting and struggling in vain, feel their hopeless wish to reach the Mortal Realm again as an invisible barrier forever shut them out of it.

That feeling spread wordlessly through the air, until at some point Duncan saw proof of it. When the oil lamp on the table flickered a certain way, when the light and shadow crossed at just the right moment, he suddenly saw a mark appear on the nearby wall. It looked like the deep gouge left by a sword swung with full force—but when he looked again, the flames of the oil lamp wavered, and the mark vanished without a trace.

That was the last time those three believers of the Sun made contact with the Mortal Realm.

Duncan let out a quiet breath, turned with the pigeon, and left the room.

Outside the abandoned break room was a passage much narrower than the sewer corridors he had seen before. The deep, long passage stretched in both directions. One end led to a branching tunnel. The other connected to a ramp slanting upward.

Even though this area had been abandoned, the city's administrators still clearly kept up some basic maintenance of these underground facilities—at least the gas lamps along the passage were still lit.

Duncan quickly judged the direction of the passage. Then, using the fragments of memory left in his mind, he worked out the route to the surface and soon strode toward the sloping ramp.

He walked faster and faster.

Fresh air began to appear. A cool breeze blew Duncan's hair back. He heard faint, distant sounds, probably the roar of some factory on the surface running through the night, and, even farther away, the sound of waves… the sound of nighttime surf breaking against the rocks along the shore.

Duncan almost broke into a run.

Now free of the spirit-form flames and back to normal, the pigeon AI flapped its wings on his shoulder and called out happily: "The times are calling! The times are calling!"

Duncan suddenly stopped. He stared into the pigeon's eyes: "Don't talk randomly when we're outside—normal pigeons don't talk."

AI thought for a moment, then beat its wings hard: "Aye, captain!"

Duncan was genuinely surprised. The pigeon had actually responded to him correctly for once. He did not know whether it was a coincidence or something else—but soon he stopped thinking about it.

He had to get ready to face this world.

He definitely could not walk outside in a black robe. In the memories he had “devoured”, this suspicious robe was only worn at secret rituals for the Sun’s believers. On the streets of the city above, showing up in such clothes meant getting tied to a tree and beaten by half a dozen patrol squad members.

The city-state of Pland had very strict curfews. Wandering at night seemed quite dangerous. Ordinary people who wanted to go out after dark had to carry permits and file in advance—this cultist whose body he had taken clearly did not have such legal papers. So if he wanted to move through the city, he had to avoid the night patrols.

Those responsible for keeping order in the city at night were called “Guardians”. They seemed to be the armed force of the Deep Sea Church. In the memories Duncan had absorbed, this body’s original master felt deep fear and hatred toward those armed priests…

Duncan quickly sorted through the memory fragments in his mind. Since they came from a corpse, the pieces were messy and vague. He could not piece together a complete life story of a “member of modern civilized society”, nor could he assemble all the details about the city-state of Pland. But even the most basic parts were enough to give him a rough idea for his next moves.

First, he took off the black robe at the foot of the ramp leading to the surface. Underneath was normal clothing that would not draw attention outside.

He considered burning the robe, but flames and smoke might draw the patrols. In the end, he only rolled it up and hid it in a corner near the ramp.

The Sun charm amulet was also something that might bring trouble. But it could also hold valuable information. After some hesitation, Duncan decided to keep it. Later, when he returned to the Vanished, he could use this charm amulet for another test and see if AI could bring it back as well.

He could study it safely aboard the Vanished.

After carefully smoothing away all traces of the hidden robe, he straightened himself up a bit, trying to look like an ordinary citizen instead of a cultist who had been skulking around, filthy and hunted, in the sewers. Only when all that was done did he step onto the ramp.

The rest of the way was not far.

Duncan hurried up the sloping path. Ever fresher air filled his chest. He could now clearly hear the sounds of distant factories and waves. A few minutes later, he even saw a faint, cold light spilling across the steps ahead.

He strode forward a few more steps, and that pale light finally bathed him completely.

He had reached the surface.

Solid, steady ground, washed in a dim, pale glow.

Duncan’s eyes widened. He saw a city—a city standing on the Boundless Sea, a city that represented mortal civilization. A huge scar in the sky stretched over it, lighting up the tightly packed rooftops, towers, and buildings in the distance. Not far ahead lay a somewhat worn-down fringe district. Farther away, on higher ground, he could see many distant, grand structures. That was the Upper City, where the great Cathedral and City Hall stood.

Duncan suddenly started laughing. No sound came out, but he laughed until he was out of breath.

After a short while, he forced himself to stop. He took a deep breath of the cold night air, then strode off in a direction he remembered.

cultists also had their own “normal lives”. Aside from a few “priests” who made harming others their full-time job, the Sun Church, like most other cults, relied on large numbers of ordinary people to keep running. These bewitched grassroots believers were mostly poor citizens from the lower layers of the city, overlooked old people, naive youths who had barely stepped into society, or people like the one whose body Duncan now occupied…

A sick, unnoticed ordinary person running a shady little antique shop in the Lower City, struggling against life and taxes.

The miserable life of the antique shopkeeper named “Ron” had come to an end. His debt to some evil deity had been wiped clean with his last breath. But he had still left a place for himself in this world… and Duncan liked that place very much.

Chapter 40: Landing

Vanna jolted awake from a bizarre, chaotic dream and found that it was still deep night outside the window. The cold, pale light of the World's Wound fell on the windowsill engraved with the runes of the Deep Sea, making everything look calm and quiet.

Yet the scenes from that strange dream still stood out clearly in her mind.

A ship – a great ship wreathed in green ghostly flames – had sailed out from the line where sea and sky met. It rolled over the city-state of Pland like a crushing mountain. In the ghostly fire, countless shouts and desolate songs roared together, as if they meant to overturn the whole world.

At the same time that the great ship descended, she had seen a blazing sun rise from deep within Pland. It was not the Sun people knew, the Sun bound by ancient runes, but a burning star like the "ancient Sun" the Sun believers described. It rose from the depths of the city-state; its flames melted the land, and everyone turned into flowing wax statues, running like molten wax through the streets.

The great Cathedral of the Deep Sea Church had stood quietly at the center of that city of living fire, like the heart of a purgatory. In the dream, she had prayed toward the Cathedral, hoping for the Storm Goddess's guidance. But the great Cathedral answered only with noisy, meaningless bells. No guidance came…

Vanna sat up in bed and, still in her nightclothes, walked to the window. She glanced at the quiet city outside and the "World's Wound" in the sky, but

the unrest in her heart only boiled harder.

A moment later, the young Inquisitor drew her gaze back from the city. She went to the dressing table by the bed and pulled open a drawer.

There lay a dagger inside, its blade bending in strange curves – a ritual dagger. At the base of the blade, the runes of the Deep Sea Church glimmered faintly, as if stirred by some unseen force and resonating in answer.

Vanna's eyes rested on the glowing runes for several seconds. Then she drew the blade across her palm, opening a cut. As blood seeped out, she held her hand across her chest and softly spoke the name of the Storm Goddess, trying to seek the God's guidance.

But for some reason, she heard only unreal roaring waves. The "Psychic Sensing" state that she usually entered with ease did not respond at all tonight.

It was as if an invisible Veil had suddenly fallen around her, cutting off her link with the Storm Goddess Gamona.

Vanna's brow slowly furrowed.

Interference in the link between a believer and a God was very rare, but not impossible. The mapping between Subspace and the Mortal Realm was deep and complex, far beyond mortal understanding. Even a God's power could sometimes be weakened or strengthened for a time, layered through the influences of Subspace, the Abyssal Deep Sea, and the Spirit Realm. On top of that, the endless struggle between the Gods, and between the Gods and the Elder Gods, never truly stopped. In extremely rare cases, it was possible for a believer to suddenly lose the God's voice.

But the Storm Goddess Gamona… should not be like this.

The Boundless Sea surrounded mortal civilization. The Storm Goddess's power ran through every dimension and touched the whole Mortal Realm. Any God might lose contact with the Mortal Realm for a time; even the Death God sometimes left loopholes like the "Revenants". But the Storm Goddess… that was impossible.

This was one of the reasons the Deep Sea Church could become the most powerful Church upon the Boundless Sea.

So was the problem in herself?

Vanna naturally began to doubt her own condition. But when she looked at her palm, she saw that the cut she had just made was already healing fast.

The Goddess's divine blessing was still there. It took effect without the slightest delay.

Vanna recalled once more that noisy, grotesque nightmare, and the ominous signs she had seen over the past many days.

There had to be a link between all of it.

The ghost ship burning with green flames… the ghost ship…

Vanna quickly searched through her occult studies knowledge in her mind, comparing fragments, and her gaze suddenly grew serious.

She was not an expert in seafaring and rarely dealt with those absurd tales that passed among superstitious sailors. But even in orthodox Church texts, there was one ghost ship that held a special place.

It was an ominous ship that had returned from Subspace. Its captain was the terrifying man who, a century ago, had led to the Viseran Thirteen Isles being swallowed by a Border Collapse – Captain Duncan.

Vanna straightened suddenly behind the dressing table, but at once she remembered: it was the middle of the night. The Cathedral's archives, like

any other library, were not open at this hour.

And for safety's sake, she should not talk with anyone about the dream's contents in the few hours right after such a "prophetic vision dream" ended. If the dream truly pointed to that "Captain Duncan", then he might well use the link formed by the dream to sense mortals discussing him in return.

After all, he was a "ghost" who could return from Subspace…

The safest course now was to wait patiently. She had to wait until the Sun once more took its place as the world's ruler, until the link forged by the dream slowly faded. Then she could go to the archives to look up related records, or seek out the Archbishop in the Cathedral to discuss these ominous prophetic visions.

No matter what, if these prophetic vision dreams truly pointed to that "Captain Duncan", if they really warned that the legendary Vanished now had its eye on Pland, then as Guardian of the City-State she had to stop that terrifying ghost captain from making landfall, no matter the cost…

…

A tall, gaunt shadow moved quickly along the empty streets of the Lower City, its thin figure casting a fleeting outline under the gas lamps.

The city was completely unfamiliar. The buildings were completely unfamiliar. Vague, half-formed memories drifted in his mind, and the commoners' district, under curfew, felt cold and eerie.

Yet as Duncan walked through these shabby alleys, he was in an unusually good mood.

He had done it. Not only had he successfully carried out a second walk in the Spirit Realm, he had also managed to control a body and come to the surface – to the surface of the city-state of Pland.

He was making contact with the civilized society of this world. He was seeing this era's buildings and this era's technology with his own eyes.

And he was using a complete body this time – no gaping chest, no opened skull. A body that looked normal from the outside would make his next moves much easier.

To be honest, this body's health was not very good. Even though his Spirit Realm walking state let him ignore most of the body's problems, Duncan could still clearly feel its sub-healthy condition. But he had no complaints. He even felt it was only natural.

After all, from his two experiences so far, Spirit Realm walking always took over a corpse that had been dead for some time. How could anything still jumping around be a corpse?

A distant barking came from the end of the street. Duncan cautiously slowed his steps and hid himself in the shadows between two buildings.

He did not know if it was a patrol dog led by one of the Church Guardians on night watch, but there was no harm in being careful.

Above the nearby buildings, huge pipe structures crossed over the low houses. The light of the "Pale Scar" spilled between those pipes in broken bands of shadow and glow. Now and then, steam leaked from valves along the pipes, spreading into a hazy mist in the night.

The barking faded into the distance.

Duncan stepped out from his hiding place, looked up and down the street for any movement, then absently soothed the pigeon AI, which shifted on his shoulder, before following his memories toward the opposite side of the street.

Among a row of low, two-or three-story buildings was an old door. A dirty signboard hung above it, and on either side of the door the walls held grimy,

poorly cared-for display windows. It was a shop, not a small one by the look of it, but clearly neglected and doing poor business.

This was the place the shards of memory in his mind had led him to.

He walked up to the old door and looked up at the sign. A row of letters could just be made out in the dark:

“Ron Antique Shop,” Duncan muttered under his breath. “A simple, straightforward name…”

After that, he felt around by the door. His memories were not very clear, and he searched for quite a while before finally finding a spare key on a hidden hook under the window ledge.

The original owner of this body had not kept the key on him, nor carried anything that could show his identity or lead someone back to this antique shop. It seemed like the caution of a seasoned cultist. But for a ghost captain who could seize memories, this kind of surface-level caution meant nothing.

Duncan opened the door of Ron Antique Shop, slipped inside, and quickly shut it behind him.

The wooden door banged shut, but the sound did not carry far into the night. The signboard above the door shook and tilted a little. The letters on the board squirmed in the cold, pale night, and in the blink of an eye, new words emerged on the wood –

“Duncan Antique Shop.”

Chapter 41: Inside the Antique Shop

The inside of the antique shop was just as Duncan had guessed – messy, worn-down, and steeped in the feel of failing business. Just from the dust piled up around the display windows, a visitor could imagine how badly the shop's owner had let his life fall apart.

He first saw the display tables along the walls. Their low, sturdy tops held large vases, statues, and some totem-like things of unclear meaning. Behind the tables, the walls were divided into cubbyholes for smaller "goods". The counter stood straight across from the door, a long bar-like structure. The shelves behind the counter were dusty as well, filled with dark-toned picture frames and small ornaments.

Behind the counter he could also see a staircase leading up to the second floor. It lay in dimness, its structure hard to make out for now.

There was a small door under the stairs. In his "memories", that door should lead to a storeroom at the back of the shop – half of which was piled high with junk.

It was hard to imagine that the cultist he now possessed had actually lived off this shop that looked like no one would ever visit, and even had spare money to make offerings to the Sun God's priests.

Duncan walked toward the counter at the back. The old wooden floor creaked under his feet. As he passed the stairs, he noticed the lamp fixed to the wall.

It was an electric lamp.

Duncan’s brow furrowed at once.

The lamp’s style was unfamiliar. The iron frame and dull lampshade both had an exotic look. But the tungsten filament bulb inside was clear at a glance – the light source was electric.

So in this world, electricity was already this widespread? Even ordinary commoners in the Lower City used electric lights in their homes?

Then why had the light sources in the sewers earlier been gas lamps, oil lamps, and torches? Why were the streetlights outside also gas lamps?

A huge doubt rose in him. It clearly went against common sense, especially in a place like the sewers. Compared to clean, safe electric lights, gas lamps that used flammable gas and open flame had obvious disadvantages!

He had thought before that technical limits forced the city’s administrators to use gas lamps down there for light. But now it seemed that, at least in the city-state of Pland, technology had already developed to the point where electricity had entered ordinary homes!

A huge sense of wrongness filled Duncan’s heart. He tried to search his memory fragments for matching knowledge, but all he got were answers like “this is common sense” and “the city is planned that way”.

It seemed that either this kind of knowledge was simply not public, so the cultist he possessed knew nothing about it, or it was so basic that it left no deep impression in the cultist’s mind at all, and so the memory blurred quickly after death, leaving only a vague feeling of “of course it’s like this”.

With this unsolved confusion in his heart, Duncan reached out and turned on the electric lamp. With a soft click of the switch, bright light immediately lit the area around the stairs and the counter.

There was another switch on the wall opposite, used to control the lights in the rest of the first floor, but Duncan did not plan to touch it yet.

It was late at night now. One small light in a closed antique shop could still be explained as “the shopkeeper getting up and moving around”. But if every lamp suddenly blazed on, it could draw unwanted attention.

By the limited light near the stairs, Duncan first glanced over the goods closest to him. The first thing that caught his eye was a wooden, totem-like object less than half a meter tall. Red and blue paint formed a strange mask-like pattern on the wood. Beside it stood what seemed to be a ceramic antique vase. In front of them lay price tags marked with absurd sums.

Original price: four hundred and twenty thousand. Discounted price: three hundred and sixty.

It fairly radiated a kind of self-mocking despair.

Duncan quickly looked away and swept his gaze over the rest of the shop.

If there was a single genuine piece in here, he would ram the Vanished straight into Pland’s city walls.

Nothing could have been more fake. He did not even need a real collector to appraise them; anyone with a normal mind would never believe a true antique was being sold in an antique shop down in the Lower City. Would anyone who really dealt in antiques open a market in this kind of slum quarter? The oldest thing in the whole shop was probably the sign over the door…

But Duncan was not surprised that this kind of shop existed. The shopkeeper knew he was selling fakes. The people who came here did not really expect to put a thousand-year-old statue in their homes either. Everyone knew the score. Commoners in the Lower City also needed some way to satisfy their spiritual needs. The “antique shop” sign over the door

was not hung for others – it was hung so the buyers could show it to themselves.

After all, under the overpasses back on Earth there had been people selling "jade" too – bracelets going for ninety-eight a piece, proudly called old-mine icy jade. Take one home and bump it on a doorframe by accident, and you would chip glass all over the floor. Did the buyers and sellers really not know what was going on?

Duncan had no interest in the shopkeeper's miserable past life. He cared about only one thing: this place could serve as the first "foothold" on land for the captain of the Vanished.

A forward base for learning about the world on land and about modern civilized society.

He had already made up his mind. As long as Spirit Realm walking allowed it, he would keep this body going as long as possible and use this "antique shop" as cover for his movements in Pland. And if AI's training went well later – if AI could truly transport physical objects in a stable, controlled way between the Vanished and Pland – then this antique shop would also become a secret warehouse for transferring supplies.

Duncan went behind the counter and sat down on a chair, carefully sorting through the fragments of memory in his mind and picking out every point that might pose a risk.

The original owner of this body had been a believer of the Sun God, but in the whole Church system he was only a lowest-level member. Because the city-state's authority had kept cracking down on cult activity, the space for Sun God believers in Pland had been squeezed to the limit. Their members were extremely cautious in how they contacted each other. They always wore full hoods and masks to any gathering, and many low-level members had contact with the Church's upper ranks only through one or at most two

specific “handlers”. For the Duncan of today, this was without doubt a good thing –

It meant that even among the cultists, only that one person knew “his” identity and contact methods in the Mortal Realm. Once that person was gone, no one else would know his unspeakable heretic identity.

He could then walk right in front of the city-state’s administrators as an upstanding, clean citizen.

And the even better news was that, after carefully combing through his memories, Duncan confirmed that this biggest hidden danger had already vanished.

Because “his” handler had been one of the three black-robed cultists he saw when he first woke up…

Those three unlucky fools had already been “taken care of by the pigeon”.

He relaxed a little inside and shifted into a more comfortable position on the chair.

With the greatest risk gone, if there was still anything to worry about, it was the other Sun God believers who had taken part in the sacrificial ritual in the Underground Assembly Hall earlier, and, behind those believers, the larger and more secretive, dangerous Sun God Church.

If his memories were right, four years ago the city-state of Pland had carried out a harsh strike against the Sun God Church that lurked in the city. Since then, that heretic faith had never recovered in the city-state. Forget holding rituals; on normal days, they were already thankful if they could hide themselves well enough not to be dragged out by the Church Guardians.

But now, these extremely low-key cultists had suddenly done something very high-profile.

The purpose of a sacrificial ritual was to please a God, and also to gather power or strengthen the God's influence on the Mortal Realm. The cultists in the hall at the time – even that priestly "Envoy" who led the ritual – had all been only rank-and-file members of the Sun God Church. Would rank-and-file members like that organize such a big scheme all on their own?

Duncan's memory fragments were not many, and a low-level cultist would never have touched the Church's core secrets. But even just reasoning from the information he had, he could guess that those cultists who had suddenly stirred things up must have been acting under orders from higher up.

That heretic sect that worshipped the "true Sun God"… they wanted to do something big in Pland. The sacrificial ritual that he had accidentally ruined was probably only the smallest splash before the start of that great event.

Duncan did not feel much for this "city-state of Pland". But if he wanted to use it as his starting point, then he had to think about how a bunch of madmen like those "Sun God cultists" running wild in the city-state might affect him.

Chapter 42: What He Saw in the Book

The city was under curfew, so it was not a good time to go out exploring. Duncan stayed in the antique shop the whole night. The excitement of finally setting foot on land kept him going, and he tirelessly searched through the entire building.

The original master of this body really had been a cultist, but at the same time he was also an ordinary person who needed a normal life. He needed the conveniences of modern civilization to survive, needed to talk to people, and needed all kinds of everyday goods.

He needed to deal with the entire city.

And all of that would leave a lot of clues. Even with his memories blurred and broken, Duncan could still roughly work out how people lived in the city-state of Pland, and what the era's technology and living conditions were like.

Behind a secret compartment in the counter on the first floor, he found a small stash of cash: a handful of loose coins and several blue and green notes of different values. This was the legal currency used in most city-states, certified and issued jointly by their governors and the Boundless Sea Chamber of Commerce. The main unit was called the "Sola", with the "Peso" as a subsidiary coin worth one-tenth of a Sola. The cash Duncan found added up to just over two hundred Sola, and according to the

information in his memories, that was about enough to keep a family of three in the Lower City alive for a month.

So it seemed that even though business in the shop had been poor, and even though most of his property had been donated to the Church, the original master of this body still managed to maintain a basic standard of living—proof that this antique shop still had a steady trickle of customers.

The first floor of the shop had only two parts. About two-thirds of the space was the storefront in front of the stairs. The remaining third was a "warehouse" behind a small door under the stairs, and at the back of that warehouse there was another door—the building's rear entrance, which was probably also used for bringing in goods.

The layout on the second floor was a bit more complicated. Besides a washroom, there were two rooms, one large and one small, and a narrow shaft shared with the neighboring building that held pipes and ducts. The big and small rooms sat on either side of the stair landing, and they were both surprisingly clean.

There was also a tiny kitchen on the second floor, but judging from the layer of dust on everything, it probably had not been used for at least half a month.

After checking everything, Duncan went back to the main bedroom on the second floor. He looked around the room, which was even smaller than his old studio apartment, and his gaze fell on the small cabinet beside the bed.

There was a framed picture there, and inside it… was a black-and-white photograph.

The photo showed a family of three: a plainly dressed young man and woman with a little girl who looked only four or five years old. They stood

in front of an obviously painted garden backdrop, faint smiles on their faces as they looked toward the camera.

Duncan walked up to the frame, picked it up, and studied it carefully, trying again and again to match it with the vague, scattered fragments in his memory.

The original master of this body… was not in the photograph.

The people in the picture seemed to be this body's relatives… very close ones.

When he fixed his gaze on the young couple, Duncan seemed to feel a faint sense of longing rising up from the depths of his borrowed memories.

But everything else about the photograph was blurry and indistinct. It was as if all the deeper memories about them had vanished from this world with the original master of this body's last breath.

He set the photo down and wondered what kind of expense a black-and-white portrait like this would be for a commoner in the Lower City. He also wondered how far photography had developed in this world, and what principles the equipment used.

At the same time, his gaze drifted to the neatly made bed, and a faint doubt rose in his heart.

Would a cultist who had completely fallen into the faith of the Sun really spend so much time keeping his room this clean?

The storefront downstairs was clearly neglected, so how was the bed in this bedroom kept so immaculate?

He walked out the door and crossed to the smaller room opposite the stairs. Inside, the bed and desk were just as tidy and clean.

He sorted through his memories and confirmed that the original master of this body had left the shop several days ago to go to the Secret Assembly Hall for a gathering of the Sun's believers—that had been his last time leaving. The details were already hazy, but there was no impression of him tidying up the rooms before he went.

So that meant… there was someone else?

Someone else had been living together with this cultist? A relative?

Duncan frowned slightly. While he searched for matching clues in his mind, he walked over to the desk in the small room. His eyes passed over the neatly arranged paper and stationery and finally settled on a book.

The book lay in the most prominent spot on the desk. Its cover was a deep blue, decorated with gears and connecting rods, and the title was written in elegant cursive letters:

"The Art of Steam and Gears – General Textbook III"

Duncan frowned. He already vaguely realized that this room must belong to "someone else", yet he still picked up the book without thinking.

There were no books to read on the Vanished, and he had not found a single scrap of writing in the master bedroom or anywhere else in the shop. This book in his hands might help him understand more about this world.

He opened the cover, and the illustrated pages came into view. It really was a "textbook" on engineering techniques and the principles of steam machinery, and between its paragraphs he could see many notes left by the book's owner.

The neat, delicate handwriting looked like it belonged to a young woman.

Duncan rubbed his forehead. The original master of this body seemed to have had almost no relatives or friends. Most of the scenes—or rather

impressions—in his memories carried a cold, lonely tone. But after combing through them several times, he finally “recalled” someone, dimly… a girl with dark brown hair.

She seemed to be the only person that the cultist named Ron still cared about, in a way, when he breathed his last.

Duncan’s gaze fell on the pages. He did not bother with the parts full of specific technical terms and diagrams. Instead, he picked out the sections that read more like editors’ notes and discussions of concepts.

A line of text suddenly caught his eye:

“…Fire, or to be more precise, the special flames produced by burning oils from the Deep Sea and crystalline minerals from nearshore deposits, is the keystone that keeps modern society running and protects our civilization…

“The prosperity and order of modern civilization are built on fire and steam… Clean, convenient electricity cannot replace the exorcising effect of fire, nor can it keep large machines running steadily for long periods of time… Experiments have proved that steam is the most stable form of power when exposed to the influence of the deep layers of space…

“In this chapter, we will discuss three typical designs for steam cores and explain the mechanical principles and design ideas behind them…”

Duncan’s eyes froze for a moment.

He remembered the gas lamps, torches, and oil lamps he had seen everywhere in the sewers before, and the gas streetlights along the roads of the city. He also remembered the puzzlement he had felt when he saw that lone electric lamp in the shop.

So… this was the reason behind those seemingly “strange” things?

Even in the risky environment of the sewers, people still insisted on using open-flame lamps. Even with electricity already developed to a certain level, they still lit the streets outside with gas lamps—all because “fire” could, to some extent, hold back the spread of certain “Dangerous Aberrations”?

A vague, hard-to-name feeling rose in Duncan’s heart. His gaze moved down the page to the complex schematics, the dense notes, and the careful annotations left by the book’s owner.

They were machines he simply could not understand.

And they were definitely not the “steam engines” he had known in his previous life.

The intricate gears, the extremely complex cylinders, and the pipes and valves linking each part all went far beyond the concept of a simple steam engine. They looked more like devices that had jumped out of some fantastical illustration manual, full of a strange, contradictory beauty.

This was the “heart” that kept this world’s civilization moving forward.

Lost in thought, Duncan slowly put the book back where it had been.

Because he could no longer make sense of it at all.

As someone from Earth, even with his past experience as a teacher, he could not make heads or tails of these steam-powered mechanisms pushed to such extremes.

Yet even so, a faint sense of insight still surfaced in his heart:

The development of civilization in this world seemed to be walking a path completely different from the one he knew.

To survive in a world surrounded by threats, mortal nations had taken on all sorts of bizarre forms. But no matter how strange a world was, as long as it

could still be called a “civilization”, there had to be reasons and logic behind how it had grown to this point.

The gas lamps burning in the sewers, the electric lamp glowing in the shop, and the steam engines drawn in the book—born from the gathered wisdom of countless people—all faintly revealed a certain… tenacity.

Chapter 43: Good Morning, Mr. Duncan

Duncan put the book back, then checked the rest of the furnishings in the room. He did not find anything else of real value. There were pitifully few belongings in this small bedroom, and it did not seem to be used often. The most useful clues were still that textbook and the two old notebooks in the desk drawer.

The notebooks were filled with notes on steam engines and engineering principles, with a few complaints about certain teachers or classmates scattered between the pages.

It was easy to reach a conclusion from that: the person living here was a young student still in school.

Duncan slowly sorted through the fragments of memory in his head. After he put everything in the room back where it had been, he returned to the main bedroom.

He sat on the edge of the bed and thought for a while. Then he stood up and walked to the standing wardrobe beside him, opening its door almost by muscle memory and pulling out one of the drawers.

A few bottles of strong liquor lay hidden in the back of the drawer, along with half a box of pills used to ease pain and calm the nerves. These were things the cultist named Ron had left behind in the world.

He had suffered from a serious illness that had already worsened beyond any cure. Cheap liquor and painkillers that only helped for a while were always kept in the drawer, but such things obviously did nothing to extend the life of a man trapped in sickness.

So this man, who had lost all hope in life, turned to the Church of the Sun. The preachers told him that the healing power of the Sun could cure all stubborn illnesses in the world and purify the body and mind of those who converted. And to a certain extent, those cultists really did keep that promise:

They had bloody, twisted rituals that used fresh blood as a medium, channeling the life force of innocent people into the bodies of sick believers. Duncan did not know how those rituals worked, or whether they could truly cure incurable diseases. He only knew, from the fragments of memory that remained, that after one such ritual the cultist named Ron had indeed improved, and so he became even more devoted to the Sun, going so far as to donate more than half his property to the “Envoy”.

But Duncan was not very interested in what had happened among those cultists who were already dead.

He reached deeper into the drawer and soon felt a hidden compartment. After fiddling with it for a moment, he found a revolver and a box of bullets still in good condition.

The city-state of Pland did not forbid citizens from owning guns, but they needed proper paperwork. A fake antique dealer living in the Lower City clearly lacked the money and status to get a gun license, so this was without a doubt an illegally owned weapon. Out of caution, the original master of this body had left the gun in the room instead of taking it to the gathering. He probably used it to protect his shop in daily life. But now, it belonged to the captain.

Of course, Duncan knew this was just an ordinary weapon. Compared to the “anomaly” creatures on the Vanished—or even to the old-fashioned flintlock on his ship, which might have special powers that surpassed this revolver—it was nothing. But he was someone in the Mortal Realm now. He knew moving around the city-state of Pland was not the same as acting on his ship. The body he was using now was made of flesh and blood, and many parts of this city were far from safe.

After all, he could not solve every problem by having the pigeon take care of people—when AI moved in earnest, she made too much noise and would easily draw unnecessary attention from the Church’s forces in the city.

Just then, a faint sound suddenly caught Duncan’s attention.

He heard the scrape of a key from the direction of the shop’s front door downstairs, followed by the sound of the lock turning and hurried footsteps.

Duncan quickly tucked the revolver against his body, and only then did he notice that it was already broad daylight outside the window—he had been busy in the antique shop all night. The pigeon AI suddenly started chattering on his shoulder: “You have a new short message!”

“Quiet,” Duncan said quickly, glancing at the pigeon as he walked toward the door. “Stay in the room until I give the word. And if there’s anyone else around, don’t speak.”

AI flapped her wings at once and flew to a nearby cabinet. “Aye, captain!”

Duncan hurried out of the room, and just as he reached the top of the stairs, he heard the quick footsteps already coming up. A young, breathless girl’s voice rose from below: “Uncle Duncan? Is that you back?”

A moment later, a girl in a brown long skirt and white blouse, with long dark brown hair, came into Duncan’s view.

She looked only seventeen or eighteen, slender and small, with what seemed like a bit of morning dew still clinging to her hair. Her features were not especially striking, but she had the fresh prettiness of her age. She stared up at Duncan standing at the second-floor landing, eyes wide, her face full of happy surprise.

Duncan did not answer. He simply stood there on the second floor. sunlight from a narrow window behind the stairs shone against his silhouette, hiding his expression in the glare. He silently looked at the girl for several seconds before finally speaking, slowly: “What did you just call me?”

“Duncan… uncle?” The girl looked puzzled for a moment, then grew a little nervous. She grabbed the stair rail beside her and peered up carefully, as if trying to see the middle-aged man’s face through the backlight. “Did I say something wrong? Did you… did you drink again? You haven’t come home for days… I just saw the light on downstairs…”

Her face and voice were all too clear to Duncan. She obviously did not yet know how—or had never thought—to hide her emotional reactions.

From the memories he had devoured, this girl should be the original owner of this body’s niece, and his only living relative.

Duncan could faintly tell that the girl did not think anything she had said was strange. She had no idea that the way she had addressed him—“Uncle Duncan”—was wrong from the very start.

Where had things gone wrong? Why would this young lady, who in theory could not possibly know his secret, so naturally call him “Duncan”?

Countless guesses surged through his mind. At the same time, he also found a few matching fragments in his memories related to this young lady—the child with dark brown hair, the last figure the original master of this body had been reluctant to leave behind in the living world.

“Nina,” Duncan said. His expression did not change and his voice stayed calm; the storm of thoughts in his head did not show at all. “Did you stay at school last night?”

“I’ve been staying at school these past few days,” the girl on the stairs answered at once. “I thought you’d be like before, gone for at least a week, so after I tidied up the house I went to stay with a classmate… Madam White, who manages the dorms, agreed. I only rushed back today because I suddenly remembered I left a book at home… Are you okay? You seem… a bit strange…”

“I’m fine, I was just a little groggy from sleep just now.”

Duncan answered in a natural tone and then started down to the first floor. An unbelievably wild guess had already formed in his heart, and now he had to confirm it.

He passed by Nina on the stairs. The young girl turned sideways to let him by, watching his eyes curiously. When he was almost down to the first floor, she suddenly asked, “Uncle Duncan, are you going out again later? Are you… going to stay home for a few days?”

“…It depends,” Duncan said without looking back, still unsure if his expression was natural enough. He only followed the tone that should exist in his borrowed memories as he answered his “niece”. “I’m just going to check the door. If nothing’s wrong, I’ll be home for the next few days.”

“Ah, okay. Then I’ll go buy some groceries later. There isn’t much food left at home…”

The girl spoke quickly as she thumped up the stairs, her footsteps fast and her voice carrying a light, cheerful note.

Duncan had already reached the shop’s front door. He took a light breath and pushed it open.

He turned around and looked up at the sign hanging over the entrance. On the old, grimy board, a line of letters stood out clearly: Duncan Antique Shop.

The first few letters were just as old as the rest. There was no sign they had been added later. It was as if they had always been there from the very beginning.

Duncan frowned and slowly walked over to the display window. Leaning forward, he studied his own face in the reflection on the dirty glass.

It was indeed a stranger's face. It did not belong to the stern, gloomy ghost captain, but to a middle-aged man with a scruffy beard, sunken eyes, and a tired look—the face of the cultist named Ron who had died in the sewers.

Duncan slowly straightened up. He could hear the district coming to life around him. The clear jingle of bells came from shop doors opening onto the street. Bicycle bells and the murmur of people talking gradually filled the road. Someone walked past the antique shop—probably the neighbor from next door—and called out to him:

"Good morning, Mr. Duncan—have you read today's paper? The Deep Sea Church seems to have taken down a big cultist hideout. That's quite the event!"

Chapter 44: An ordinary person’s Breakfast

A copy of the Pland City Bulletin cost twelve pesos, about the same as a shabby breakfast or the cheapest dessert in the Crossroad District. You could buy a paper from a newsboy passing by, or walk a little farther to the newsstand at the end of the next street and get one there.

Duncan had a few coins in his pocket. He bought a local paper at the newsstand. The boss of the stand was a middle-aged man buried in his own reading. When he heard Duncan drop the coins into the tin box, he just waved a hand to tell him to take a paper, never even lifting his head.

Duncan leaned over a little to see what the man was reading. It was an analysis of past lottery results, bright lines in all colors outlining every kind of unrealistic fantasy.

He lowered his head and looked at the paper he had just bought. The front-page headline was the piece of news that interested him most:

“The honorable Church Guardian forces, led by Inquisitor Vanna Wayne, successfully destroyed a gathering site of the Sun god’s cult, capturing a large number of cultists on the spot and rescuing several citizens…”

The photo of “Her Excellency the Inquisitor” was printed beside the article. To Duncan’s surprise, she was a rather young woman. There was a clear scar at her left eye, yet she was still a beautiful lady. Standing with her subordinates, she was half a head taller than every man around her.

Inquisitor Vanna wore close-fitting light armor and a battle skirt, and carried a two-handed greatsword that looked as if it had walked out of an age of cold steel. She was like a dashing female knight from a medieval painting. Yet behind her and the group of Church Guardians, one could see a huge steam engine, and on its metal body there were even obvious gun turrets…

It was a strange and eerie image, everything at odds and yet somehow in harmony.

Duncan's gaze stayed on the photo for a long time.

News of a cultist gathering being wiped out counted as good news for him. Here, he did not have to worry about his identity being exposed, so he could watch those villains who held live sacrifices get dragged away without any guilt at all. But more than that, he cared about the information hidden in this picture.

A female Inquisitor who specialized in hunting cultists. Fully armed steam-powered armored automatons. Church troops that carried both cold steel and firearms…

Information like this was almost impossible to get aboard the Vanished, but inside a civilized society, you could see it all clearly for twelve pesos in a newspaper.

Just as Duncan had thought before—during the century when the Vanished drifted blindly, the times had already changed.

Even if you did not look at it in the simple way of "who could fight harder," the mortal civilization represented by the city-state of Pland had already grown into something that could only be called… impressive.

The street corner was not a good place to read. Duncan rolled the paper up and tucked it under his arm. He still remembered that there was a "niece"

named Nina waiting for him back at the antique shop, so he turned and started walking back.

Compared to wandering aimlessly through the city on his own, a local who trusted him from the start was obviously a better source of information.

As for the Vanished, Duncan was not worried. Even while he walked in the Spirit Realm, he could still clearly sense what was happening aboard the Vanished, and the state of his other body. Goathead was steering the ship in his place, and Alice looked quite well-behaved. He should be able to stay active on this side for a while longer.

Anyway, the crew regulations of the Vanished already said that “the captain will occasionally leave the ship.” The captain going off to walk the Spirit Realm for a day or two did not seem like such a big deal, right?

And as he kept walking the Spirit Realm, Duncan felt his control over this special “mental projection” growing more and more skilled. Maybe soon he would be able to control both bodies at the same time. Then there would be even less reason to worry about the ship while he was walking the Spirit Realm.

At that moment, a sweet smell suddenly drifted over from the side. Duncan stopped without thinking and turned his head. He saw a cake shop by the street, with fresh pastries being set out at the front.

This was the Lower City of Pland, so of course there were no high-class dessert shops. But even the cheapest, rough cakes here were enough to make Duncan stop in his tracks.

He still had a few coins in his pocket, less than twenty pesos in all, but more than enough to buy a slice of cake.

After a brief hesitation, he walked up to the cake shop and paid for the most ordinary honey cake they had. The shopkeeper wrapped it in some thick,

coarse paper. It felt rough and scratchy under his fingers.

Holding the newspaper and the cake, Duncan headed toward the antique shop. For some reason, his mood became lighter.

Walking along the street. Talking to people. Buying things. Going back home.

Such simple things gave him a feeling as if he had lived another life. He almost savored the act of breathing on land. He treated these ordinary routines as a precious kind of life experience.

Life aboard the Vanished was not bad either. Goathead was noisy but reliable, and Alice was an interesting one. But being able to experience life on land was not bad at all.

Before long, Duncan reached the antique shop again. Before he pushed the door open, he looked up at the sign above the shop. The line of letters reading “Duncan Antique Shop” still sat there quietly, carrying the worn look of something that had not changed in more than ten years.

He pushed the door open. The bell chimed with a clear sound. Right after that, hurried footsteps came from the stairs.

A young girl with long brown hair rushed down, then stopped short at the foot of the stairs. She held onto the post beside her and stared wide-eyed at Duncan, her expression tense and worried.

“Uncle Duncan, where did you go?” she blurted out. “You said you were just going to look at the door, but you were gone in the blink of an eye… I thought you had run off to the tavern or the casino again…”

Duncan looked at the young lady in surprise. He could tell that she truly was nervous and worried.

She was worried about the only family she had left in the world, the person she depended on to live. Even if that person was a drunken, gambling, bitter wreck of a man, and secretly tainted by the bloody business of cultists.

A faint, hard-to-name feeling rose in him, but his face did not change. He said: “I just went out for a walk and bought a few things.”

As he spoke, he walked over to the counter of the antique shop, planning to set the newspaper and the cake down. Nina seemed to relax all at once, then turned and ran upstairs. As she ran she called: “Uncle, wait a bit, I’ll bring breakfast down—at this hour you definitely haven’t eaten yet, have you? I made corn and beet soup…”

Before Duncan could say anything, Nina had already vanished up the stairs. A short while later, she came back down again, carefully carrying a big tray.

On the tray was a simple breakfast for two.

Duncan watched the girl with a slightly blank expression as she bustled around. She cleared a space on the counter with practiced ease, set out the food, then went to the side and brought over an extra chair for him…

Her hands were very quick, and she moved with a kind of happy energy that seemed to come from nowhere.

Duncan watched her work and wanted to help, but found there was no place for him to step in.

He had dealt with many young people of that age, but he had hardly ever seen a child as diligent and efficient as her.

If this were Earth, she would only be the age of a high school student. Even here, she still looked like a student.

Duncan suddenly thought that living with an “uncle” who had fallen into a cult could not have been easy. Yet this young lady named Nina seemed to

have fully adapted to this life that was in no way happy, and had even found her own supports within it.

“Let’s eat,” Nina said now that everything was ready. She glanced at Duncan and went on in a tone that sounded as if she had repeated these words many times. “Doctor Albert said that if you eat breakfast regularly and keep a good mood, in the long run that will work better than strong liquor… better than painkillers.”

Duncan did not answer at once. He only looked quietly at Nina. Before her expression could turn awkward and tense, he picked up the cake he had set aside, unwrapped it, and placed it in front of her.

Nina’s eyes widened in surprise as she stared at the thing in front of her. “This is…”

“Cake. I bought it from the corner shop,” Duncan said casually. “You’re still growing. You should eat something nourishing for breakfast.”

But Nina froze. She just stared blankly at the cheap pastry. After a long moment she seemed to come back to herself, and muttered under her breath, almost to herself: “Are you really all right?”

“Of course I’m fine,” Duncan said, his expression quite natural. “I just suddenly remembered that I haven’t bought you any sweets in a long time.”

“That’s true. It’s been more than a year…” Nina muttered. Then she suddenly smiled and picked up the table knife. “Then we’ll split it half and half. Doctor Albert also said that you need nourishing food.”

Duncan felt very strange, but after a brief silence he still nodded.

“…All right.”

Chapter 45: History

This feeling was very strange.

Duncan could clearly sense things far away. He could feel the Vanished drifting on the vast Boundless Sea. That living ghost ship, under Goathead's control, was constantly opening up new routes on the enchanted sea chart. A cursed doll whose head was not very solid wandered through the cabins like an explorer, getting to know every corner of the ship. The deep, dark sea rose and fell around them, hiding countless strange things.

At the same time, through another line of sight, he was sitting in an antique shop in the Lower City of the Pland city-state. The sounds of people and carts from the street drifted in and only made the quiet inside more obvious. A human girl named Nina sat across from him, taking small bites of the cheapest cake the Lower City could offer.

He was Captain Duncan, master of the Vanished, a moving calamity on the Boundless Sea—yet here he sat like an ordinary person, eating his breakfast in the calm heart of the city.

He did not know if it was an illusion, but he felt that some part of his heart that had always been hanging and uneasy was slowly settling down. Maybe it was the nerves that had been taut for so long on the ghost ship, or maybe it was something else, but whatever it was, it did not feel like a bad thing.

It seemed she sensed his gaze. Nina, still eating her cake, suddenly looked up at him curiously and asked: "Uncle Duncan, aren't you going to eat?"

Duncan glanced at the food on her plate. "Is that enough for you?"

“It’s enough. Eating too many sweets is bad for you.”

“Mm.”

He nodded, picked up the cake, and took a bite. He carefully tasted the rich flavor he had not enjoyed in a long time, feeling the crude sweetness slowly melt in his mouth. Then he clearly sensed this body begin to process the food he had eaten.

His heart settled a little. Things were as he had expected.

This body was much more “useful” than the first shell he had occupied. Its “parts” were all intact, and it had not been dead for long. His soul had taken over and almost restarted its life force without a break. It was completely different from that open-chested corpse from before.

Now he had breath, blood flowing, and a beating heart. The heartbeat seemed a bit slow, but still within the range of a normal person.

He probably did not need to worry about the body rotting anymore, or plan how to soak himself in preservative. And this way it was also much less likely he would be exposed in front of ordinary people.

But there was one thing Duncan still was not sure about.

He knew this body should have been ill. In the memories he had devoured, the impression of long, heavy sickness was deeper than any other memory. The strong liquor and painkillers he had found in the cabinet earlier were proof enough.

He did not know exactly what illness this body had suffered. The time and cause of the sickness belonged to very old memories, already blurred. But one thing was clear: right now, aside from the weakness that came with an ordinary person’s body, he felt no problems in this body at all.

Had the disease vanished? Had this body healed itself because of his walk in the Spirit Realm? Or was his projected soul limited in what it could feel, so he simply could not sense the problem, while this body's health was still slowly getting worse?

Duncan thought about this as he calmly ate. Then he suddenly looked at Nina, who was eating across from him, and asked: "Don't you need to go to school today?"

Nina lived in the Lower City. Her family's finances were not good, but the city-state of Pland had clearly reached a point where basic education was quite common. She studied at a school run together by the Church and the City Hall, focusing on steam engine studies. This kind of school was like a vocational high school, meant mainly to send trained steam artificers to the factories and the Cathedral.

Half of Nina's tuition was paid by her uncle, and the other half came from City Hall subsidies.

For a city-state that had entered the industrial age, it was worthwhile even for the authorities to pay to train artificers like her. And it was undeniable that these very practical schools at least solved the literacy problem for commoners.

Nina was eager to learn. In her uncle's memories, this girl had done quite well in all her classes.

"I don't have any classes this morning," Nina said with a nod. "Only two history lessons in the afternoon. And I need to go tell Madam White that I won't be staying in the dormitory for the next few days…"

Duncan suddenly stopped what he was doing and looked at Nina carefully. "Don't you think staying here to take care of someone like me will hold you

back? You could live at school for long stretches. That might be better for your studies."

Nina froze. She stared blankly at her "Uncle Duncan," then suddenly got angry. "You shouldn't talk like that! You're only sick, that's all. You just need to obey the doctor and take your medicine. Dad and Mom entrusted you to me…"

"No, your dad and mom entrusted you to me," Duncan corrected her seriously, picking his words with the help of the memories in his mind. "You were only six years old then."

"But I'm seventeen now," Nina said, puffing out her cheeks as she stabbed her fork into the last bit of cake. "You're even worse than I am at taking care of yourself. If I really moved out, you'd have the room in a mess in less than three days. In fact, you can let me help take care of the shop, at least with the cleaning. The window is so dirty you can barely see through it…"

Duncan listened helplessly to the girl's rambling lecture. He had not expected an offhand "test" sentence to get such a big reaction.

But slowly, he could not help smiling.

From this girl named Nina, he felt a kind of warmth… a warmth like standing in sunlight.

"All right, I was only speaking casually," he said, shaking his head as he stirred the last bit of soup in his bowl. "History in the afternoon… how have your history lessons been going lately?"

"Uncle Duncan, are you really all right?" Nina opened her eyes wide in surprise. "You never… well, at least in the last two years, you've never asked about my schoolwork."

Duncan opened his mouth, about to say something, but the girl went on talking on her own: “We’ve been doing ancient history lately. Old Mr. Morris has been telling us about what happened after the Great Annihilation… To be honest, it’s pretty interesting. Ancient history sounds a lot like stories. It’s much more fun than modern or recent history.”

Duncan thought for a moment, then asked seriously: “Sounds like you’re doing well. Then let me test you. What is the basic idea of the Great Annihilation?”

Uncle Duncan was very strange today. Nina could not say exactly how, but he was different from usual.

But Nina did not think too hard about it. Compared to her uncle’s slightly odd words and actions, what mattered more to this simple young lady was that Uncle Duncan finally seemed to have some spirit, and even looked to be in a good mood.

She was happy that Uncle Duncan had asked about something she had just learned.

So she began to explain, wearing a proud smile, and told Duncan what she had just studied:

“The Great Annihilation happened about ten thousand years ago. For reasons we still don’t understand, minority peoples with unusual cultures, like the elves, the Senkin, and the Gyproans, record different dates in their own calendars. But overall, scholars agree that the Great Annihilation took place at the end of the Age of Order about ten thousand years ago…”

Duncan listened with a calm face.

Inside, his mind was full of questions.

Elves? Senkin? Gyproans? What was this? So there were other intelligent races on land besides humans? And elves… was that the same kind of

“elves” he was thinking of? Were there elven city-states out on the Boundless Sea, living in the steam age?

All sorts of bizarre images rose in his mind, while Nina’s voice still came from across the table:

“…Different city-states record the Great Annihilation in slightly different ways, but there are some things they agree on. Before the Great Annihilation, the Age of Order was far more prosperous, stable, and safe than today. There were vast continents then. The seas were not as endless as they are now. And neither the seas nor the lands had anything like the ‘border of the Mortal Realm’ that we talk about today…

“The time after the Great Annihilation is called the Deep Sea era. The Deep Sea era has lasted to this day and shows no sign of ending. Its biggest feature is that the Boundless Sea covers almost the whole world. Less than one tenth of the old era’s land remains, and it is broken up into islands of many sizes or ‘mistbound expanses’. The city-states we have now stand on the more stable islands, and all kinds of ocean-going ships are the only way for the islands to trade and stay in contact.

“In the early Deep Sea era, the remnant folk of the Old World suffered heavy blows. The old civilizations were almost all destroyed. The first kingdom to rise from the ruins was the ancient kingdom of Critt, the oldest civilization of the Deep Sea era that we can still trace. Even though that ancient kingdom lasted less than a hundred years, it left behind many legacies that deeply influenced later times. These include the very first and simplest ways of classifying the many anomalies and manifestations of the Deep Sea era, as well as a lot of precious knowledge on how to survive in the Deep Sea era…”

Chapter 46: Anomalies and Visions

The Great Annihilation was the turning point of all history in this world, and it was also the beginning of what people now called the Deep Sea Age.

From what Nina told him, Duncan finally roughly understood what kind of earth-shaking change had once happened in this world, and he also realized that this world had not always been as strange and dangerous as it was now.

If the historical records were true, the world before the Great Annihilation had been a prosperous, safe paradise.

At that time, the ocean was not yet the Boundless Sea. The limited waters back then did not cover more than ninety-five percent of the world's surface like they did now. Humans still lived on wide, safe land, and even in the seas there were no dangerous Visions such as the Spirit Realm, the Abyssal Deep, or Subspace.

The "Age of Order" written in the history books actually felt more like the world Duncan was familiar with. Modern people might look back with shock and disbelief at that Age of Antiquity where no "Anomalies" existed, but to Duncan, it was the current shape of the world that was utterly wrong.

The history books did not give a detailed explanation of this key event, the "Great Annihilation". Archaeologists had been working on it for years, but the city-states and peoples still fiercely disagreed about ancient history. No one knew how the so?called Great Annihilation had actually happened, or what the disaster itself really was. Thick chaos and mist shrouded that upheaval, and beyond the mist lay only the Deep Sea Age they lived in now.

Seawater from who knew where drowned more than ninety percent of the land. The survivors of civilization built city-states and fleets on the remaining islands and scraps of ground. The Boundless Sea and the mists over it brought with them strange things called “Anomalies” and “Visions”, which still threatened the survival of civilization to this day.

But Nina did not know that the man in front of her was a ghost captain from another land, quietly drawing knowledge from her words. She only thought this was Uncle Duncan testing her homework. Uncle Duncan had not been in such a good mood for a long time. She felt simply happy, and even felt that this moment was especially precious, because she worried that at any time Uncle Duncan might turn back into how he had been before… and from her past experience, that was almost unavoidable.

As soon as the liquor stopped working or the painkillers ran out, Uncle Duncan would become especially irritable, quick?tempered, and hysterical.

So before Uncle Duncan fell ill again, she wanted to show him all the progress she had made. Maybe that could make his good mood last for another day or two.

“…Old Mr. Morris is very interested in the history of the Critt Kingdom. He is an expert in that field. He told us that even though the ancient kingdom of Critt only lasted for a hundred years, it was the first civilization to stand up from the ruins and fight against Anomalies and Visions after the Deep Sea Age began. The experience they gathered in that hundred years still guided most people in the world even today. The most important part of it is their way of classifying ‘Anomalies’ and ‘Visions’…”

“The way they classify ‘Anomalies’ and ‘Visions’? You’ve already learned that?” Duncan raised his eyebrows, and his words still carried a bit of mental guidance.

He had cared about this ever since he started listening. Now he was even more sure that, in the eyes of ordinary people in this world, the unnatural things were strictly divided. Some things were called “Anomalies” and even had numbers, but other things… seemed to be called “Visions” separately, instead of being lumped together with all the rest as “Anomalies” like he had first thought.

Back on the Vanished, he had never heard any detailed knowledge about this from Goathead. Now the things Nina was learning at school could finally make up for this gap in his basic understanding.

Nina nodded. She thought back to what she had heard in class and said: “The simplest way Old Mr. Morris taught us to tell the difference between Anomalies and Visions is by scale.

“Usually, Anomalies are smaller in scale. They are often limited to a single object, a single animal, or even a single ‘person’.

“Most Anomalies can be moved by people, and their range of influence is limited. Many Anomalies only affect a single target at any one time. If you know the right methods, most Anomalies can also be safely sealed or isolated. Some of the less harmful Anomalies can even be ‘used’ like tools through special methods.

“Visions are much larger in scale than Anomalies. The smallest Vision is as big as a whole house. Larger ones can cover an entire city?state, or even more… so large it is hard to imagine.

“A good number of Visions cannot be moved by human hands at all. They are either fixed in one place, or they move according to their own will. Their ability to affect things also far surpasses that of Anomalies. Most of the time, a Vision can affect an unlimited number of targets within the area where it works, so much so that it is almost the same as a ‘natural phenomenon’. That is why they are called ‘Visions’.

“Unlike Anomalies, almost all Visions cannot be sealed or controlled. They exist in the world like natural phenomena, working without any outside interference, and they naturally affect every target within their range that meets the conditions. Because most Visions are dangerous, all people can do is stay away from these dangerous Visions, or use special methods to keep themselves from becoming targets inside a Vision’s active range…

“Luckily, the most dangerous Visions usually do not move. The pioneers helped us find out where those dangers are, so we can safely keep our distance from them…”

Nina spoke very seriously. Then she suddenly seemed to remember something and quickly added: “Oh, right. Old Mr. Morris also especially reminded us that these rules and traits are only ‘usually valid’. Anomalies and Visions are things that go against common sense, so no matter how people sum up their experience, there will always be Anomalies or Visions that do not fit the definitions and suddenly appear. Sometimes an Anomaly and a Vision can even switch places, and there are cases where Visions can be interfered with or destroyed by human hands.

“For example, in the year 1830 of the New City?State Calendar, there was an Anomaly in the city?state of Lunsa called ‘Mycelium’ that entered a runaway state. The local Church guardians paid a heavy price to banish that runaway?state Anomaly to a nearby island. In 1835, that island was reclassified and promoted to a Vision and became what was later known as Fungal Isle—but in 1844, the great Saint Paladin gave his life to contain Fungal Isle inside his own ash urn. The Vision ‘Fungal Isle’ was struck from the rolls that same year. It turned back into an ‘Anomaly’ and was renamed the ‘Paladin’s Mushroom Jar’. It is now sealed in the sacred relic vault under the great Cathedral of Lunsa city?state…”

Duncan listened with full attention to everything Nina said. His mind worked quickly, while his calm expression hid the waves in his heart.

In this short breakfast alone, the information he gathered had already surpassed everything he had learned in all those days on the Vanished.

Building contact with the land and setting up an outpost in a city?state on the surface had indeed been the right idea. Civilized society was where most of the world’s information was gathered.

He looked without thinking at the girl still talking in front of him and felt a lot of emotion.

A normal civilization that had developed to the industrial stage would surely try every way it could to compress and collect the basic knowledge needed to run society into its education system. A child living inside that system might find it hard to notice what a treasure those textbooks they saw every day really were.

They were knowledge that countless people had built up over countless years, then sorted and organized again and again into forms that were easiest to learn. Those books were the most delicate “compressed rations” of knowledge in the world, meant to turn a blank sheet of a person into a working part of society with the smallest possible cost of time and effort.

Even Nina, who normally loved to study, could not feel this. Only an “outsider” like Duncan could see how precious this knowledge was, and how easy it was to absorb.

Nina did not notice what Duncan was thinking. She only remembered what her respected history teacher had said in class—

“…So at the end of the last class, Old Mr. Morris said one more thing to us. He said that people had summed up countless rules while dealing with ‘Anomalies’ and ‘Visions’, but only one rule was truly always valid. That rule is: ‘No matter how many rules we sum up, there will always be Anomalies or Visions in this world that do not follow them.’

“Scholars also call this rule the ‘Eternal Clause Zero’. By default, it is placed at the very beginning of all books and papers in the related fields. Based on it, people came up with the famous ‘Perpetual Miscalibration Law of Anomalies and Visions’. Up to this day, that law has never been broken…”

Chapter 47: Before the Sacred Icon

Nina was very happy, because it had been a long time since she had sat down for a normal meal like this with Uncle Duncan and talked about what was happening at school. It had been even longer since she had seen a smile on Uncle Duncan’s face.

It even made her think of the past, of the time before her uncle fell ill. She had lost her parents when she was six. Since then, this man who was like a father to her had become her only family in the world. But four years ago, a sickness whose cause even the doctors could not find had turned her uncle into someone else. The days since then… to be honest, had been very hard to endure.

Her uncle still paid for her schooling and kept up her basic living expenses, but Nina could feel that every bit of color that had once belonged to the “future” had slowly faded from this small, familiar, cozy shop. It had been washed away by the hard liquor, the pills, and those gloomy, oppressive gatherings with the shady “friends” who dealt with her uncle.

She no longer dared to hope that life could go back to how it had been a few years ago, but even a small improvement was something worth being happy about.

Duncan was happy too, because he had finally come into contact with more information about this world and finally touched the threads of its history. Even if it was only a part of it, it gave him the joy of having the fog briefly pushed aside.

The completely lost prehistoric “Age of Order”, the “Great Annihilation” that reshaped the order of all things, the Deep Sea Age that had lasted to this day, the Anomalies and Visions spread across the world… all these things that he had once not known at all, or only half understood, now finally had clearer outlines.

Breakfast ended. Nina stood up to clear the dishes. Her movements were quick and practiced, and it was easy to see that she did this kind of housework often. Without a doubt, she was the one who cleaned the upstairs bedroom too.

A man weighed down by serious illness, sunk in decay, and pouring most of his energy and passion into cult activities clearly would not be doing these things.

But as he watched the girl busy herself, Duncan still could not hold back in the end. He stood up and took the large tray from Nina’s hands: “Let me carry this. You look like you have trouble going up the stairs with it.”

Nina stared at Duncan in surprise. She had just opened her mouth to say something more when he was already striding toward the stairs.

The girl could only hurry after him, following behind while she reminded him: “Uncle Duncan, be careful. The doctor said your condition is still unstable…”

“The doctor… Doctor Albert?” Duncan did not look back. He went up the stairs while he searched his broken memories for a matching image, but only caught a few brief flashes. “It doesn’t matter. He still can’t figure out the cause of the illness anyway. The most effective medicine he prescribed was just painkillers.”

“…You should still listen to the doctor’s advice,” Nina muttered as she followed Duncan up to the second floor and walked toward the kitchen. “At

least he knows how to keep you healthy…”

Before Nina could finish, the sudden sound of flapping wings cut her off.

She and Duncan looked toward the source of the sound at the same time and saw a shadow flash past the crack of the half?closed master bedroom door.

“Uncle Duncan, something just flashed past inside your room!” Nina said in surprise, then stepped forward and grabbed the doorknob. “Could it be the cat from next door…”

“Hey, don’t…”

Duncan only had time to get out half a warning before Nina pushed open the half?closed door. The pigeon hiding in the room then appeared before the two of them.

AI was standing on top of the cabinet, one claw holding a French fry halfway to its beak. The sudden opening of the door froze the entire bird in place. It stayed there with one claw still pushing the fry toward its mouth, its two little pea?green eyes staring blankly at Nina and, with the other eye, at the wall on the other side.

Then it saw Duncan. Its wings flapped twice with a loud noise: “Ah… coo?”

The corner of Duncan’s eye twitched. Not far away, the window stood wide open. That was clearly AI’s escape route. In the distance, straight out from the window, he could vaguely see a pier bathing in the sunlight.

This pigeon had gone to the docks to score some fries and flown back with them…

“A pigeon?” Nina finally reacted. She stared in surprise at AI on the cabinet. “Uncle Duncan! There’s a pigeon in your room!”

“I see it,” Duncan said with a blank face. “I don’t know it.”

AI instantly threw away the fry, flapped over with a fluttering sound, and landed on Duncan’s shoulder, bobbing its head.

“Fine. It flew in this morning,” Duncan sighed. “It might be someone’s tame pigeon, but it isn’t very bright. I gave it something to eat and then it refused to leave.”

AI listened and let out a loud coo.

If there had not been an outsider present, and if Duncan had not given an order earlier, it would surely already be loudly crying out “ah, yes, yes, yes” by now.

Nina did not doubt her uncle’s words at all. She only looked at the pigeon with shining eyes, then slowly came closer, watching its reaction while she asked Duncan: “Then… are you going to keep it? Can I keep it?”

The girl’s thoughts were written all over her face. In her eyes, AI was clearly just a pretty and cute white dove. AI tilted its head to look at Duncan and gave a questioning coo from its throat.

Duncan suddenly felt that this bird was easier to understand when it did not talk…

After a moment, he pretended to hesitate, then nodded: “You can—but only if this pigeon is willing to stay. It might fly away at any time. You can’t complain when that happens.”

Nina’s face lit up at once. “Great! I knew it, Uncle Duncan, you really are reasonable deep down!”

…

In the central prayer room of the great Deep Sea Cathedral, the city?state Bishop Valentine, wearing a black priest’s robe embroidered with gold,

stood with a solemn face before the holy image of the storm goddess.

He was tall and thin, with sparse white hair and eyes as calm as deep water.

The great candelabrum in the prayer room burned quietly. The sacred flames lit the chamber. The holy statue of Gamona towered on the dais. This goddess had no face; her head was covered by a black veil, and a long dress patterned with many waves fell from her body down to the edge of the platform. Though it was only a stone statue, the power of divinity still showed itself here. The whole image gave off a strong sense of presence. Anyone standing near it could feel a faint sense of being watched by a gaze and being sheltered.

That feeling of being under a gaze and under protection was real. It was under that gaze and that shelter that Vanna, who had come to discuss a matter with the Bishop, could calmly and openly speak of all the scenes she had seen in her dreams.

“…If what you saw in your dream was accurate, then that truly was the Vanished.”

Bishop Valentine of the city?state turned around and looked at the young Inquisitor who had come to him early in the morning. In terms of Church ranks, the battle?focused Inquisitors and the ceremony?focused city?state Bishops were on the same level. But when it came to judging supernatural events, it was completely normal for an Inquisitor to seek advice, or even guidance, from a Bishop.

“So it really was the Vanished?” Even though she already had an answer in her heart, Vanna still could not help widening her eyes after hearing the Bishop’s judgment. “I thought that…”

“You thought that ship was now just a legend, like all those ghost?ship tales the jumpy sailors brag about in taverns?” Valentine knew what Vanna

wanted to say. The old man with sparse white hair shook his head, his voice deep. “The existence of the Vanished is a fact recognized by all the city? states and the Church. It is not a legend. You can find records of it in the Church archives.”

“I know that. The Vanished did truly exist. In Pland’s City?State Archive you can even find some of the construction blueprints and launch records for that ship from more than a century ago. But all of that solid, verifiable material only covers the time when the Vanished was still a ship sailing in the Mortal Realm, and when Captain Duncan was still human…”

Vanna spoke in a serious tone. She glanced at the holy statue behind the Bishop, and her expression grew even more careful when she mentioned certain words.

“The key point is that the records clearly state that the ship fell into Subspace. A century ago, thousands of fleeing dead from the Viseran Thirteen Isles saw with their own eyes as that ship and their homeland were swallowed by a Border Collapse and plunged straight into the shadows of Subspace. In the decades after that, there were always reports claiming that the Vanished had appeared again in the Mortal Realm, but all of them lacked real proof. Quite a few scholars doubted that the ship had ever truly ‘returned’…”

The young Inquisitor spoke as she looked at the old man before her.

“Is it really possible for something swallowed by Subspace to appear again in the Mortal Realm?”

“…So far, nothing except the Vanished has ever returned to the Mortal Realm after falling into Subspace. Even for the Vanished, only later sighting reports exist, and scholars in every field doubt whether that ship truly came back. That is indeed the truth. But that is not the key point…” As the old man spoke, his gaze suddenly fell on Vanna, and a strange kind of

seriousness appeared on his face. “The key point is, Inquisitor, are you afraid of something?”

Chapter 48: Vigilance

Before the statue of the Storm Goddess Gamona, the candles of the divine blessing burned with a calm, steady light. Daylight fell from the dome above, spilling around the statue and making the city-state's Bishop, cloaked in pitch-black robes, seem as if he bathed in divine grace.

Bishop Valentine raised his head in that light and quietly fixed his divine gaze on Vanna's still-steady gray eyes. His words seemed to carry a kind of magic. Faintly, Vanna heard the sound of gentle waves rising and falling in her mind, and then the rolling crash of thunder followed. With the help of that outside force, the power of the Goddess finally tore through the veil and exploded in her heart.

Vanna suddenly sucked in a deep breath, as if she had broken free from suffocating depths and leapt back onto dry land. Her chest rose and fell sharply, and her heart pounded. The feeling of the God's divine gaze pressed down on her like a vast weight. In that half-dazed state, she heard Valentine's voice continue in her ears:

"The Vanished had records in history. The prophetic vision dream you experienced was also an objective fact. With both of these in place, your normal reaction should have been to first assume the threat exists, and then seek a solution. Yet just now, you subconsciously questioned whether the Vanished truly exists. That means you are, deep down, avoiding the message that the prophetic vision dream brought to you.

"Inquisitor, you are subconsciously denying the existence of the Vanished. That itself is proof that the ship is real. It seems it truly is drawing near the

borders of the civilized world."

Vanna felt a thin layer of sweat form on her forehead. Yet that "veil" that had always hung between her and the Goddess now felt as if it had vanished. This actually eased her heart a little, and the Bishop's words made her realize what had happened:

Without knowing it, she had already been influenced by the Vanished.

This was exactly the trait many terrifying Visions or Anomalies possessed: they twisted the perception of those who came into contact with them, making people subconsciously ignore and deny them. In this way, the influence grew larger and larger without anyone noticing.

This kind of subconscious ignoring and denial was originally a natural defense of intelligent beings, an instinct to avoid danger. But when dealing with an Anomaly, that very instinct became the source of carelessness. In the end, it quietly turned people into victims of Visions and Anomalies.

As an Inquisitor who often dealt with supernatural powers, Vanna knew this kind of knowledge very well. But she had never thought that she herself would fall into such a "mental trap". Her own strong will had not worked at all?

"I don't know when I came under its influence," she said calmly. Standing before a Bishop who was also a devout Believer, Vanna did not hide the weakness that had just been exposed. Being affected by a Vision or Anomaly and slipping into a mental anomaly was the most normal thing in the world. Shame and concealment would not help. "After waking from the prophetic vision dream, I came straight here. I did not speak with anyone on the way, and I did not touch any scrolls or relics. I believe I did not suffer any outside corruption in that period."

“But you just now clearly showed a deliberate avoidance of the prophetic vision dream… so the influence must have started earlier,” the Bishop said. Valentine focused his divine gaze on Vanna’s face, as if he watched every change in her eyes and every shift in her breath. “Have you come into contact with anything abnormal lately? It may have been corruption from the Vanished, leaving an anchor in your subconscious ahead of time.”

“Lately…” Vanna frowned. Then she suddenly remembered the “sacrificial victim” who had fallen at the Black Sun ritual site in the sewers. She remembered the green fire flashing in the person’s eyes, and she remembered her own severed finger.

Her eyes widened. Vanna suddenly looked straight at the Bishop and asked: “The day before yesterday, I led the team to clear out that Black Sun ritual site in the sewers. After I came back, did I report any nameless corruption at the scene? Did I report that there was a ‘sacrificial victim’ there who had been corrupted?”

The Bishop shook his head: “No… you sent those cultists to the Cathedral and then went straight back.”

Vanna’s heart gave a jolt. “What about the others who joined the operation that day? Did anyone report anything like that?”

“There were no such reports at all. Every file only recorded matters related to the Black Sun heretics.”

Under the Goddess’s statue, the Bishop gazed at Vanna, and Vanna gazed back at the Bishop.

“It seems we have found the moment when the corruption first ‘came ashore’,” the Bishop said with a quiet sigh. His expression stayed calm, but in his eyes, strength brewed like a storm about to break. “In the holy name

of our Lord Gamona, Inquisitor, are your memories from that night still clear and complete?”

Vanna took a deep breath: “In the holy name of our Lord Gamona, I still remember every detail from that night.”

The Bishop nodded. He turned and lit a special incense, then set the bronze censer at the base of the statue. As he did so, he spoke in a steady voice: “What happened at the time?”

So Vanna laid out everything that had happened in the ritual site beneath the sewers, just as she remembered it. She did not skip a single detail. With the help of the holy incense, her memory and her thoughts were clearer than ever. The events of that night returned to her as if they were happening again.

She still remembered the moment the sacrificial victim suddenly opened his eyes. She remembered the emerald flame that leapt in the hollows of his eye sockets. She remembered the fire falling onto her finger, and how she had decisively carried out the purification by cutting that finger off. On the way back to the Cathedral, she told herself in silence: the corruption has been completely purified, the corruption has been completely purified, the corruption has been completely purified…

She muttered those words to herself the whole way back. Every Guardian walking beside her muttered the same words as well.

No one thought anything about it was wrong.

Looking back now, she felt how terrible and eerie that scene really was. Under the bleak night sky, the Church’s squad of Guardians walked through silent, empty streets. Every single one of them murmured the same sentence to themselves over and over until they returned to the Cathedral.

And during all of this, they still believed they were acting normally: watching the captured heretics, cleaning the filthy ritual site, escorting the cultists on the way back…

"…The spirit-form flame fell upon the soul. The purification you carried out at the level of the flesh by cutting off a limb was useless. It only gave you a deceptive comfort," Valentine said at last. "The correct action would have been to burn incense at once, sprinkle holy oil on the ground to form a temporary holy ground, and then call upon the Goddess through a ritual prayer to carry out purification of the 'spirit'."

"…This was my fault," Vanna said heavily. "I should have been more alert and more quick to react."

"It was a mistake, but not a sin," the old man said with a shake of his head. "You are very powerful, but as an Inquisitor you still lack some experience. Luckily, you have now broken free of the influence. That means the corruption left on that sacrificial victim was not too strong. It only interfered with you on a mental level. From the incense ritual just now, I could roughly judge its strength."

Here he paused, as if he weighed and judged something in his mind. Then he went on: "The Guardians who acted with you should have been affected even less. They only stood around you. Their influence should fade quickly as they keep praying in the Cathedral.

"In general, the corruption you all suffered at the time was fierce and strange, but the source had already been cut off. So the later effects were not truly frightening. From your performance just now and from the incense's feedback, I would say that even if you had not come here today, you would have noticed something was wrong by yourself in a few days.

"More than this, we need to worry about what comes next."

“The future…” Vanna repeated the Bishop’s last word. Her expression slowly grew serious.

Yes, the future. This matter was not over.

The scenes shown by the prophetic vision dream were warnings sent down by the Goddess. What she had come in contact with so far was most likely only the prelude to a coming storm.

“The Vanished has not appeared within the sight of the civilized territories for many years,” Valentine said. “Many people believed it had already gone back to Subspace and become one of the countless shadows in the deepest parts of the world. But now, it seems that Captain Duncan still clings to the Mortal Realm.”

Bishop Valentine spoke slowly as he turned, gazing up at the statue of the Storm Goddess.

“A century ago, the Vanished fell into the depths of Subspace,” he said. “There was no clear proof, but many eyewitness reports mentioned a great storm roaming the nearby sea at the time. In some ways, that storm played a role in the ship’s fall…

“The storm is our Lord’s divine authority.”

Vanna frowned: “You think Captain Duncan means to… take revenge on the Goddess?”

“It is hard to say,” Valentine replied. “Even for a ghost returning from Subspace, the idea of taking revenge on a deity is almost unthinkable. Gods dwelled in the Divine Realm. The Divine Realm lay hidden above the Mortal Realm. Everything in the world only ever fell downward from the upper world. No one ever heard of anyone climbing in the opposite direction, from the Mortal Realm up to the higher ‘Divine Realm’…

“But if Captain Duncan wishes to take revenge on our Lord’s agents in the Mortal Realm… that is very possible.”

“The holy Storm Grand Cathedral, as the headquarters of the Deep Sea Church, is a Pilgrimage Ark that sails hidden on the Boundless Sea,” he went on. “It comes and goes without a trace. The Pope, His Eminence who sits aboard that ark, holds the power to wield the storm in the Lord’s stead. He is not an easy target.

“By comparison… the city-state of Pland, fixed upon the sea, obvious, and open to the world, naturally becomes a better choice. Aside from the Storm Grand Cathedral, Pland is the Storm Goddess’s greatest faith anchor in this world… and it is a faith anchor anyone can visit.

“From that point of view, it is only natural that a vengeful wraith would choose to land in Pland.”

Chapter 49: Two Looming Stormclouds

The gods dwelled in the Divine Realm, far from the world of the Mortal Realm. People believed that special dimension was the keystone of the world. Unlike common belief, this “keystone” did not sit at the bottom of everything, but at the very peak of all dimensions.

In the records left behind by the ancient kingdom of Critt, their scholars described the structure of the world they knew like this:

The world’s keystone lay at the very top, guarded by eternal truth and order. The Divine Realm rested within that keystone, existing by itself from the beginning.

Below the Divine Realm lay the Mortal Realm, where all living beings dwelled. The people of the dust enjoyed the afterglow of order at this level and could live in a world that was relatively stable and rich.

Below the Mortal Realm lay the Spirit Realm, which slowly slipped away from mortal understanding. In the Spirit Realm, the gods’ divine blessing had already thinned. Twisted, uncanny forces started to gain the upper hand.

Below the Spirit Realm lay the Abyssal Deep Sea. It was no longer fit for living things. Strange, weird powers ruled there, and it hardly counted as part of the material world at all. It was more like a hollow reflection of nothingness.

Beyond the Abyssal Deep Sea, lay the very bottom of the world: the depths of Subspace, where the shadows of all things gathered. The true bodies of extremely dangerous Elder Gods and many other wicked beings lurked within Subspace.

In the records of ancient Critt, the gods made a covenant within the keystone. That covenant was the source and standard of all laws in the world. Order flowed down from there. It set the rules by which the world operated and soaked into all things. As one went deeper and deeper, the power of order weakened and was gradually overcome by the forces of Subspace. The “keystone” where the gods resided and the depths of Subspace were like the upper and lower ends of the world. Order flowed one way between those two ends.

This was the ancient gift left to later ages by that brilliant civilization that had led the way in the era of the Deep Sea ten thousand years ago. Over the long ages since, countless Scholars studied this “layered structure” with all their strength and never found a fault in the model. By now, it had already become the world’s accepted “World Standard Model”.

In this standard model, mortals of the dust could fall into deeper places, but there were very few who could return from the deep layers to the “shallows”. Every once in a while, there might be one or two lucky souls who returned to the Mortal Realm from the Spirit Realm. But no one had ever heard of a being who defied the heavens and traveled from the Mortal Realm to the keystone dimension where the gods dwelled.

Because of this, the return of the Vanished from Subspace to the Mortal Realm became the most outrageous Vision in this world. Its return voyage broke everything people believed about the World Standard Model.

But on the other hand, the existence of the Vanished also fit that classic doctrine about Anomalies and Visions: the law of permanent misalignment

for Anomalies and Visions.

No matter how one looked at it, Bishop Valentine and Vanna did not believe that ghost captain had the power to take revenge on the Storm Goddess herself. Even if he had the heart for it, he still could not do such a thing.

For the keystone and the world of the Mortal Realm were not continuous. Unlike the link between the Mortal Realm and the Spirit Realm, or between the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep Sea, there was no chain of steady falling or direct exchange of matter between the keystone and the Mortal Realm. So far, no Scholar had found any proof of a direct connection between the keystone and the Mortal Realm. Not even a deity could descend with its full self. At most, a deity could send down projections or commands as symbols of its will.

So how could a single ghost ship ever “strike back” at the Divine Realm?

If the ghost captain could not take revenge on the Storm Goddess herself, then of course the only choice left was the Goddess’s Believers in the world of dust.

The Storm Grand Cathedral, as the headquarters of the Deep Sea Church, was a Pilgrimage Ark that sailed hidden on the Boundless Sea. It appeared and vanished without a trace. The Pope, His Eminence who sat upon that ark, held the power to wield the storm in the Lord’s name, and he was not an easy target.

So the city-state of Pland, fixed upon the sea, obvious to all, and open to the outside, naturally became a better choice. In this city-state, eighty percent of the people were Believers of the Storm Goddess.

Vanna had already decided in her heart that the ghost captain had come for revenge. After all, a hundred years ago, the Vanished had fallen into Subspace in a storm. Aside from revenge, she could think of no other reason

to explain why the Vanished, which had been missing for so many years, would suddenly return to the Mortal Realm and point its prow at the city-state of Pland.

But what exactly did that ghost captain plan to do?

Vanna frowned and, deep in thought, slowly spoke: “Bishop Valentine, do you think… the Vanished is connected to the recent unrest among the Suntists in the city-state?”

After speaking, she paused and then added: “In last night’s dream, I saw a burning Sun appear in Pland together with the Vanished. Two disasters arriving at the same time may be the prophetic vision the Goddess gave me…”

“But don’t forget, in the underground ritual site, that ‘sacrificial victim’ who had been corrupted killed the Black Sun priest,” the Bishop said with a shake of his head. “That priest was an ‘Envoy’ who had undergone baptism. At least at that ritual site, the Vanished and the Black Sun seemed to stand on opposite sides.”

For a moment, Vanna said nothing, only sank into thought at the Bishop’s words. Across from her, after a brief silence, the old man spoke again: “As for those cultists who worship the Black Sun, I did receive some reports about them this morning from the city-state of Lunsa…”

Vanna immediately looked up: “Reports?”

“The Sun heretics are not only rising again in Pland,” Valentine said with a nod. “They have been stirring in many city-states lately. A large number of Sun heretics have recently passed through Lunsa and Morka Harbor as transfer points and are gathering toward Pland. Some of them were caught. During interrogation, those heretics mentioned ‘Sun fragments’.”

“Sun fragments… the remains that flaked off after that so-called ‘true Sun god’ in their mouths broke apart?” Vanna reacted at once. “They believe one of these Sun fragments is hidden in Pland?”

“That is how it seems for now,” Bishop Valentine said. “No one knows where those heretics got their information. It might have been some ‘revelation’ they received in their crazed state. In any case, they are now convinced that part of their ‘lord’s’ remains lies hidden in this city.” His expression stayed calm. “They see this as the hope for the Black Sun’s revival.”

“…That group of madmen,” Vanna muttered a curse under her breath. “To revive that dark, blasphemous Sun, how many lives have they already taken?”

“‘Black Sun’ is what we call it. In their minds, the Sun god shines with brilliant light and represents the truest order,” Valentine said, shaking his head. “You cannot expect that pack of deranged cultists to keep any conscience when their hands drip with blood. They are sure that everything they say and do is righteous. When dealing with them, only two languages are useful. One is caliber. The other is poundage.”

Hearing this remark, which carried a very Deep Sea Church style, Vanna could not help but twitch the corner of her mouth: “Sounds like we are going to be busy.”

“The Boundless Sea was never peaceful, and the city-states sit in the Boundless Sea as well,” Valentine said. “Captains must face the storms of the ocean. We must face the storms brought by fools on land. Inquisitor, be ready. The city-state of Pland may be facing a challenge.”

“Two challenges,” Vanna corrected him very seriously. “Aside from the Black Suntists, there is also that strange and terrifying ghost captain. If the

Vanished and the Black Sun really are not on the same side, then our troubles have gone from one to two."

Bishop Valentine paused in thought: "There is another possibility. Going by what happened at the sewer ritual site, the Vanished might end up fighting the Black Suntists."

"…Then two troubles would merge into one world-ending trouble, Bishop Valentine," Vanna said as she looked at the old man, whose thoughts were clearly starting to drift. "A ghost ship returning from Subspace and a group of cultists fighting over Sun fragments, all clashing inside the city-state of Pland, and possibly joined by a Black Sun descent in the middle of it… I can't imagine anything worse than that."

Valentine sighed and admitted that Vanna was right.

"In any case, we should first work with the Constable forces and round up all the Sun heretics who have slipped into the city-state," Vanna said. Now that she had thrown off the mental interference of the Vanished and moved into her area of expertise, her thoughts grew noticeably sharper. "We should remove the threat of the Black Sun before the situation grows serious. That is a goal we can realistically achieve.

"As for that ghost ship… we have no idea what it plans to do next, so there is nothing we can do for now. All we can do is strengthen our monitoring of the Spirit Realm and the seas around the city-state…"

Here, the young Inquisitor could not help but shake her head. Her expression was serious yet helpless: "Damn it, who could ever guess what a ghost captain plans to do next…"

…

"I want to add a bit more ketchup…" Duncan waved to Nina across the table and said: "Pass it over, I can do it myself."

Nina quickly handed the ketchup bottle over: “Okay, Uncle Duncan.”

It was already noon. Duncan and Nina sat in the small kitchen on the second floor, eating lunch. The food in the antique shop was very simple—a kind of salty fried pancake that was a local specialty of Pland, served with ketchup or hot sauce, plus a thick vegetable soup. It was hardly some fine feast, but both Duncan and Nina ate with real enjoyment.

Duncan had not eaten such a normal lunch in a very long time. Nina also had not eaten such a normal lunch in a very long time.

Duncan felt that he had begun to like this place.

Chapter 50: Public Visions

After lunch, Duncan watched Nina clear the table. He had wanted to help wash the dishes, but she firmly stopped him with the excuse: “Uncle, your health isn’t good. The doctor said you should stay away from cold water.” So he had no choice but to lean near the stairs, reading the morning paper while watching the girl bustle around in the kitchen.

This everyday scene, like something from an ordinary family’s home, made him feel a little strange inside.

Just then, Nina’s voice came from the kitchen: “Uncle Duncan, is there any news in the paper?”

Duncan lowered his head and glanced at the newspaper. First he saw the date: “New City-State Calendar, August 14, 1900.” Then his eyes fell on a story about a Church Inquisitor leading a team to arrest dozens of cultists. It was clearly the biggest front-page headline in the whole paper.

“It says here an Inquisitor led a team and caught dozens of Sun heretics,” he said casually. “It also says this is the largest heretic gathering the Church has broken up in the past four years. After that there are some reminders, telling citizens to stay safe at night and to watch for heretical beliefs around them.”

“Ah, I heard about that on my way here too!” Nina quickly put the clean dishes into the cupboard. “So scary. My teacher told us before that those cultists who worship the Sun even offer living people as sacrifices to the Sun god… Who would be so utterly insane as to believe in a cult like that?”

Duncan suddenly did not know what to say. Whatever he said, it felt too awkward. Should he mention that he had recently had an immersive experience with the full sacrificial-rite package on that altar? Or should he say, Your Uncle is exactly that kind of raving mad cultist?

But one thing was obvious. From Nina's reaction, she clearly did not know that her "Uncle" was a Sun heretic. She even had normal values like an ordinary person. She thought those live sacrifices in the Sun faith were something terrifying.

In her eyes, her "Uncle" was only a man who had become irritable because of illness, drank too much, and had a few "strange friends".

The body Duncan now occupied might indeed have belonged to a man with blood on his hands, but at least that man had raised Nina to this day. Until now, he had kept the girl outside the faith of the Sun god.

Maybe one day in the future, a cultist named "Ron" really would fall all the way, and drag his last living relative into that bottomless abyss. But at least before today, none of that had happened.

And it would not happen in the future either.

"Uncle? Why did you suddenly stop talking?" Nina turned curiously at the silence behind her, a look of concern in her eyes. "Are you feeling unwell again?"

"No, I just drifted off a little," Duncan came back to himself and shook his head. "You're right. That really is something only madmen would do… The paper also tells citizens to stay safe and report any heretical behavior in time. So for now, try not to wander anywhere except school and home."

Nina nodded, then suddenly let out a small "ah", looking a bit nervous and hesitant. "But… but I already made plans with a classmate. In a couple of days we're going to visit the City Museum…"

“The City Museum?” Duncan asked offhandedly. “Which City Museum?”

“The one near the school, by the edge of the Upper City, the ocean City Museum,” Nina explained. “I heard they’re showing near-shore mineral specimens… Is it alright if I go?”

“If you want to go, then go,” Duncan thought for a moment, then nodded. “Right now the streets are full of Church guardians and city-state constable patrols. Those cultists probably won’t be bold enough to jump out in the next few days.”

Nina nodded happily. “Mm!”

“Do you still have to go to school this afternoon?” Duncan asked again.

“Mm. This afternoon is history class. I really don’t want to miss old Mr. Morris’s class,” Nina said, nodding. “He’s a very famous expert in the field of history… But it’s strange. Someone as famous as old Mr. Morris, why doesn’t he teach in an Upper City university? Why did he come to a public school in the Lower City instead? More than half of the classmates don’t even like history. They all sleep during his class…”

Duncan calmly shook his head. “How would I know?”

What a joke. Never mind that history teacher, old Mr. Morris. Duncan had only just met Nina herself. He would have to rummage through hours of memory just to remember where Nina’s public school was.

And even the original master of this body probably had not known much more about his niece’s situation. When Duncan took over his life, that man had already sunk too deep and for too long into the Sun heresy.

Nina still had class in the afternoon, so she did not stay long in the antique shop after lunch. She quickly tidied up, grabbed the textbook she had left at home, and then the girl jogged out of the house. From the antique shop to that public school in the Lower City, the trip took nearly an hour. If she did

not waste even a minute, she might just avoid being late for old Mr. Morris’s class.

Of course, the city had public transport. Even in the relatively backward Lower City, steam-engine trams and trackless buses rumbled through the streets. But those needed tickets costing four to six peso.

Nina had smiled and told Duncan that running more was good for one’s health.

If she had a bicycle, her way to school would become much easier. Duncan had seen people riding such vehicles on the streets of the Lower City.

In a society that had already developed steam machinery, bicycles were not so expensive that ordinary people could never afford them. But for residents of the Lower City, they were still far from cheap. Even the most ordinary bicycle could cost a family of three half a month to a month of living expenses. It was a real burden.

Duncan did not know where the identity he now held would go in the future. But as he watched Nina jog away and disappear around the corner of the street, he still felt that, if he had the ability, he really should treat this young lady better.

If only for the vegetable soup and salty pancakes she had made before.

All the more so because she was a hardworking, eager student.

Maybe he should seriously think about ways to make money in these “Civilized City-States”.

With all kinds of thoughts turning in his mind, he put down the newspaper, slowly walked to the end of the second-floor corridor, opened the narrow window there, and stared blankly for a moment at the city street bathed in sunlight.

In this world, “Anomalies” and “Visions” had long gone hand in hand with the progress of civilization. Neither the authority nor the Church hid matters of the extraordinary from the public. Even a young lady like Nina, still in school, could learn about Anomalies and Visions directly from her textbooks.

She even knew the classification standards for Anomalies and Visions that the ancient kingdom of Critt had left behind, standards that were still in use. She also knew the public numbers and names of some Anomalies and Visions whose rules had already been partly understood.

Yes, this part of the knowledge was openly shared with the whole society, though not all of it.

The authority and the Church of every city-state recognized a common list. On that list, the most famous or most dangerous Anomalies and Visions each had their own special number. These numbers were not eternal. In special cases, some Anomalies and Visions might be destroyed or transformed for various reasons, and their numbers might be reassigned or left empty. But no matter how that changed, one thing was always certain:

Any Anomaly or Vision that had its own independent number and name was sure to have some special danger or power.

The authority had made part of the register of Anomalies and Visions public. On one hand, this was to make sure every citizen could know about these particular dangers and have basic self-protection. On the other hand, it was because some Anomalies and Visions were simply too close to everyone’s daily life.

These things had already seeped into every corner of ordinary life and into every part of society’s operations. People could see them at any time. There was no way to hide them, and no need to hide them.

Duncan lifted his head and silently turned his gaze to the sky.

Vision 001, the Sun.

The huge glowing orb that ran across the sky, the great Vision that had ruled the heavens in the Deep Sea Era, had been born on the morning of the second day after the ancient kingdom of Critt collapsed.

Range of influence: the whole world. Scope of influence: limitless. It moved and operated on its own, and no human power could interfere with it. It fit the definition of a Vision.

History records said that on the day the ancient kingdom collapsed, the sea raged and the city-states shattered. The entire first royal dynasty went bravely to their deaths in the darkness, their blood soaking the sea. Then Vision 001 rose from the ocean. From that moment on, the Boundless Sea finally had peaceful daylight.

The ancient kingdom of Critt was the first city-state civilization built by survivors after the Deep Sea Era began. It lasted only one short century, yet left countless legacies that still blessed the world today.

The word “Critt” in the ancient tongue meant “Eternal Night”.

That had been a veil of night lasting a full century.

All of this was written in Nina’s history textbook.

Chapter 51: Dual Operation

This world had gone through astonishing upheavals. With the “Great Annihilation” as a turning point, even the basic laws of the world had been turned upside down. The Deep Sea Era after the Great Annihilation and the Age of Order before it could almost be seen as two completely different “worlds”.

But even so, some people still worked tirelessly, sorting through all the historical materials passed down since the Great Annihilation. They tried to piece together the true shape of history from the broken and even contradictory archives of the various city-states.

Unfortunately, maybe because the break in transmission had been too complete, or because the contradictions between the city-states’ records were too chaotic, people still had not found any relatively complete and trustworthy history from before the Great Annihilation.

No one knew what the world of the Age of Order had really looked like.

But fortunately, the world after the ancient kingdom of Critt had left behind a relatively clear historical line. City-states on the Boundless Sea had risen and fallen, split and merged again and again, but the continuation of civilization itself had never been cut off. The memory of that ancient kingdom had remained, whether written in books, carved into stone, or passed down generation after generation in old, hidden families and societies. Much had been lost, but a rough thread still remained.

Scholars believed that the reason civilization in the Deep Sea Era could survive under such harsh conditions and endure to this day owed more than half of its credit to the sacred miracle that shone upon the world:

Vision 001, the Sun.

This was the Vision with the widest influence and greatest power that humans currently knew of. In fact, because its scale was so vast, and its existence felt so “natural”, many scholars argued about whether the Sun itself was really a Vision or a natural phenomenon. But the very first recorders after the fall of Critt, the survivors of that ancient kingdom, had simply called it Vision 001. That old number had been handed down ever since and had never changed.

Clearly, not all Visions were terrifying and harmful. Vision 001 brought safety to the world for half of every day. In the daytime under the Sun’s light, the corruption from the world’s deep layers was almost completely held below the surface of the sea. Only because of this stable daylight had the city-state civilizations been able to develop to what they were today.

According to records left by the ancient kingdom of Critt, after the Deep Sea Era began and before Vision 001 appeared, for a full century the entire world had been shrouded in the veil of night. The cold, dim glow of the World’s Wound had shone on the Boundless Sea for one hundred years.

So the people of the ancient kingdom had called their land “Eternal Night”, and even used it as the name of their era.

Duncan stood at the narrow window, deep in thought as he looked at the world under the sunlight.

What had the world before the Great Annihilation really been like?

Before those terrible hundred years of Eternal Night arrived, had this world once been lit by the Sun’s light?

It most likely had. No matter how incomplete or contradictory the ancient records of the various city-states were, they all agreed on one point: the Age of Order had been an era of light, safety, and prosperity.

But no matter what, that bright and prosperous era was gone. The Boundless Sea of today was lit by Vision 001. Everyone knew this and felt grateful for the daylight it brought.

In such an age, those cultists who worshipped the “true Sun” of ancient times, and even used that to attack the Sun now hanging in the sky, calling it the “false Sun”, naturally seemed especially twisted and extreme, and were rejected by the world.

They were not only attacking the Sun in the sky. They were attacking the very thing human civilization in the Deep Sea Era relied on to struggle and survive to this day.

Yet Duncan knew that the Sun those cultists worshipped very likely was the true form of the Sun that had existed before the Great Annihilation.

In a way, those cultists had grasped a part of real history. Sadly, in this age, that truth had become the very root of their madness.

Duncan did not believe their grand wish could succeed. He did not believe they could really use live sacrificial rites to create a blazing, fusing star. The distortions of this world went far beyond imagination. The state of the Deep Sea Era could never be explained simply by “the star was gone”.

The night sky here did not hold a single star.

Duncan went back to his room and closed the door. He waved at the cabinet beside him, calling AI down from where the bird had been grinding its beak on the cabinet top.

The pigeon landed on his shoulder and tilted its head. “Who is calling the fleet?”

Duncan ignored the bird. He walked to the bed and, from the corner of the mattress, took out the Sun emblem he had hidden earlier. Then he thought for a moment, went back to the cabinet, opened the door, and found the drawer where the liquor was stored. He took out two bottles of strong liquor.

Something seemed to be stuck to the bottles. Curious, Duncan turned one in his hand and saw a small slip of paper. On it, in Nina's handwriting, were the words: "Drink less."

The note seemed to have been stuck there a long time.

Every bottle had such a note, and not a single one had ever worked.

Duncan chuckled, closed the drawer and the cabinet, then took the two bottles and the Sun emblem back to the bed. He poked AI again so the bird could see what he was holding.

"If you can, try to bring these onto the Vanished."

The pigeon flapped its wings at once and let out a proud cry. "Dear, express delivery, postage paid!"

Duncan nodded and lay down in a comfortable position, starting to prepare for the crossing.

He had been away from the Vanished for too long. The ship would be fine without him watching it, but as captain, he could not keep himself locked in this room forever.

Nina had classes this afternoon, and after class she had a few other things to do. She would be busy until very late. Duncan had already talked with her and asked her to stay one more night in the school dormitory, and come back tomorrow afternoon after school.

During this time, Duncan would just take the chance to study the details of Spirit Realm travel. At the same time, he would test the plan he had thought of before: to see whether he could control both bodies at once without completely cutting off the Soul Projection.

From how he sensed the Vanished while he was “on this side”, this should be possible.

Now that he occupied this “fresh” body, the link between him and the true body on the Vanished was clearly much stronger and more stable. That gave him confidence and inspiration.

After his thoughts slowly settled, Duncan let out a soft breath. A tiny, ghostly emerald flame burned to life on his shoulder. With a sharp crackling sound, the pigeon AI turned into its Undead-bird form in the blink of an eye, and the brass spirit compass in its chest snapped open.

Boundless darkness, glowing lines, flickering starlight. The familiar feeling surged over him like a tide, and the route back to the Vanished appeared as the brightest route in that darkness.

Duncan’s consciousness rushed along that route, and in the blink of an eye he felt his main awareness awaken in the captain’s cabin of the Vanished.

But before he completely left that dark space, he forced himself to “brake” by relying on his control over the fire of his spirit form and his own soul, trying to keep his link with that “antique shop” room…

On the Vanished, in the captain’s cabin, Duncan slowly opened his eyes.

He looked down at his hands, then around him. What he saw were familiar furnishings. In his ears came the familiar sound of waves.

He slowly rose from the chair. In the depths of his awareness, though, the sensations of another body were clearly coming through.

A faint smile slowly appeared on Duncan’s face. Then, following his own understanding, he began to use that distant link to feel and control his other body in the antique shop.

He tried several times.

In the city-state of Pland, on the second floor of Duncan’s antique shop, the “antique shopkeeper” lying quietly on the bed suddenly opened his eyes.

The next second, that body on the bed began to turn its head bit by bit with a stiff expression, looking left and right around the room like a zombie. Then it slowly moved its hands and feet, as if someone were forcing a rusty machine to move, and finally managed to get its limbs working.

If an outsider had seen this scene, they would probably have been scared into running straight to the nearest constable to report that someone here was possessed by a Malevolent Spirit.

From another point of view, that report would not have been wrong.

In the captain’s cabin of the Vanished, Duncan let these strange thoughts spin in his mind while he awkwardly used a kind of “remote view” to control that body and slowly make it move.

It was very hard. To command a body with only a distant link while his consciousness was not inside it was harder than asking a beginner to control a twenty-eight-jointed Puppet on strings.

But after many attempts, he finally managed to make the body in the city-state of Pland sit up on the bed.

The next second, the picture coming from that distant body in his mind spun wildly.

The body had fallen face-first onto the floor.

Duncan sighed. “Alright, looks like I’ll have to practice for quite a while.”

Chapter 52: The Captain Was Not Home

A single will watched through two viewpoints at the same time, controlling two bodies doing completely different things. For Duncan, this was a very new experience.

It was also an extremely hard challenge.

He felt he no longer counted as an ordinary person, but even so, it was not easy to control two bodies at once without strain. He tried hard to get used to this feeling of splitting his attention. After fussing with it for a long time, he only managed to barely control the body in the antique shop, make it crawl back onto the bed, and lie there like a corpse again.

But judging from the feedback coming from deep inside his consciousness, he believed that sooner or later he could master this skill of using one mind for two bodies. It would just need a very long time to get used to it and to train.

After he settled the body in the antique shop and left a bit of attention there, Duncan finally let out a quiet breath.

Right after finishing his walk in the Spirit Realm, the most important thing was to make sure his link to the “remote body” was still there. This was directly tied to whether the foothold he had finally found in the civilized world could be used for a long time. Once this matter was settled, his mood became much lighter, and he had the energy to focus on other things.

The sound of flapping wings came from beside him. The pigeon AI ran over to Duncan in a few quick steps. The bird puffed out its chest, its eyes and tone full of pride: “teleportation succeeded!”

Duncan’s gaze went past the pigeon and fell on the tabletop behind it.

A pale gold emblem of the Sun and two bottles of strong liquor were lying there quietly.

A smile slowly appeared on Duncan’s face, and then the smile grew brighter and brighter.

It worked! Having this pigeon carry “cargo” while walking the Spirit Realm was workable! And it was not limited to extraordinary items. Even ordinary things could be teleported over!

With a satisfied smile, he stood up and picked up the things on the table. First he checked the emblem of the Sun, making sure there was still a faint power flowing inside this extraordinary item. That power was the might he had taken over and reshaped with the fire of his spirit form. Then he picked up one of the bottles of liquor, took off the cap, and held it under his nose. A strong smell of alcohol rushed out at once.

Duncan lowered his head and glanced at AI, who had already started strutting proudly back and forth on the tabletop.

Efficient, good quality, and free delivery—he was starting to like this mumbling, odd pigeon.

The pigeon also noticed its master’s gaze at once. It rushed to Duncan’s side, tapped the tabletop with its beak, and loudly chattered: “Some fries! Some fries!”

“There are no fries on the ship for now, but I think that won’t be a problem for long,” Duncan said happily, grabbing the pigeon and cupping it in his hands. He stared into its little pea eyes. “I just don’t know how much you

can teleport each time, whether you're limited to dead objects, and whether there will be any 'packet loss'… We have to run a few more tests…"

The pigeon thought for a moment, then tilted its neck up: "Packet loss? Ah, the page disappeared…"

"…Yes, that's exactly what I'm worried about. Your name always makes you feel a bit unreliable." Duncan's thoughts drifted for a moment. The fact that the pigeon had successfully teleported more things onto the Vanished greatly excited him. It made him think of more practical experiments, not just sending supplies to the ship. But this bird's floating intelligence and loose logic always stopped him from fully relaxing. After thinking it over, he still felt they needed to do more tests before truly setting up a "supply line" between the Vanished and the shore.

With a rough plan for his next step in mind, Duncan finally rose from the chair. He walked toward the door that led to the enchanted sea chart room, but he stopped after only two steps.

He stood there and rolled his joints, then stretched his legs and arms, feeling the sensations coming from his limbs.

Flexible, strong, with no trace of fatigue or stiffness at all. It was as if he had only been sitting at the desk for a short while.

Yet he knew very well that he had "left" the Vanished for more than a day. While he was walking the Spirit Realm, his body had remained in the captain's cabin, keeping the posture of sitting at the desk the whole time.

Duncan carefully felt his bones and limbs. With his precise sense of his own body, he could almost be sure that this body had completely kept the state it was in at the moment of entering the Spirit Realm. It was as if… the instant his consciousness left, this body entered some kind of "stasis."

Was this also one of “Captain Duncan’s” special powers? Or… because his true nature now was half a ghost, he was like a ghost and never grew tired?

He wondered about it curiously, but had no clue at all.

He had already started learning the history of this world and the rise and fall of the Civilized City-States, but he still could not solve the mystery of his own body.

Still, no matter what, this did not seem like a bad thing. This body did not need much “maintenance.” That meant he could feel safer about putting part of his attention into other things.

Duncan was good at taking things lightly. Or rather, he was good at putting puzzles that had no answer yet off to one side. Once he talked himself through it, he walked to the door and pushed open the way into the enchanted sea chart room.

Captain Duncan had returned.

The oak door let out a soft creak, breaking the silence in the enchanted sea chart room. The next second, the wooden carving of Goathead at the edge of the chart table suddenly started clacking. The block of wood quickly turned its head toward the sound. Under its hollow gaze, it slowly spoke: “Name?”

“Duncan Abnomar,” Duncan said, glancing at Goathead. “I’m back.”

“Ah! The great Captain Duncan has returned to his loyal Vanished! My apologies, Captain. Your walk in the Spirit Realm was rather long this time. I need to make an extra check… After all, that is the rule you set. How do you feel? How is your mood? How is your body? What did you gain from this long walk in the Spirit Realm? Did you find something interesting? Would you be willing to share this journey with your loyal First Mate and the rest, details omitted? Did you notice I just said ‘details omitted’? Miss

Alice said that makes speech more concise. You might like this kind of concise—”

“Shut up. All the words you saved got paid back in the nonsense after that,” Duncan said, giving this noisy thing a look. “While I was gone, did anything happen on the ship?”

“Ah, Captain Duncan’s strictness and humor are as always. Your lesson is correct—everything on the ship was normal. Your loyal ‘details omitted’ perfectly carried out the steering duty you gave me. Also, Miss Alice came by twice, but nothing serious. Once she was fighting with the cables, once she was fighting with the anchor chain…”

Duncan had been about to walk through the enchanted sea chart room to go check the deck, but he stopped at once when he heard Goathead’s words. He stared, full of question marks: “Why was she fighting with the cables and the anchor chain?”

While he was walking the Spirit Realm, he could sense what happened on the Vanished, but he had not spared much attention to watch closely. He had only vaguely felt Alice wandering all over the ship to “explore”… How had she managed to turn the ship into such a lively place while he was away?

“Oh, Miss Alice was actually trying to be helpful,” Goathead answered at once. “She thought it was bad to do nothing on the ship, so she wanted to find some work. She went to sort the cables and maintain the winches—but I forgot to tell her the cables are ticklish and the anchor chain needs a nap…”

Duncan: “…”

“Captain, are you angry?” Duncan’s sudden silence made Goathead nervous at once. It shook its wooden head back and forth. “It really wasn’t anything big. Besides, a new crew member on a ship always needs time to fit in

before they get along with the old sailors—now they've already reached the 'hitting' stage. That means Miss Alice is blending into the group very fast. In fact, she is quite popular on the ship. Most of the Vanished's—"

Goathead had only gotten halfway through its chatter when hurried footsteps suddenly rang out from the deck outside. The door to the captain's cabin was yanked open. Alice rushed in, flustered: "Mr. Goathead, why are the cannonballs in the magazine rolling around and not letting me—"

Duncan silently looked at Alice.

Alice also saw Duncan standing by the chart table. Her whole body went stiff as she stared at him awkwardly.

"Well, this makes the third time," Goathead on the chart table let out a sigh. "Now she's fighting with the cannonballs… I admit Miss Alice's 'fitting in' process on the ship may be just a tiny bit too lively…"

Alice shrank her neck (maybe tightening her joints), nervously watching Duncan's blank face: "Captain, you're back, huh…"

"Mm." Duncan nodded, calm and mild. "Looks like you had a very good time on the ship while I was away?"

Alice: "…"

Chapter 53: “Spawn”

While he had “left” the Vanished, Alice’s activity on the ship had gone a bit beyond Duncan’s expectations.

He had always thought this Brother doll had the air of a graceful and proper young lady—even though she could spin her head, surf around, and talk trash. Under normal circumstances, she really was elegant and quiet. She was careful about whatever she did on the ship. In a strange place she was honest and well-behaved. When she had nothing to do, she would even lie quietly in her crate like an ordinary doll, giving off a harmless-to-people-and-animals sort of vibe.

But now, it seemed she was only that quiet when he was nearby.

The way the mood in the room suddenly sank made Alice a little nervous. She carefully glanced at Duncan’s expressionless face: “Captain, you’re not mad, right? I can explain…”

“I know. You were trying to help, you just didn’t succeed,” Duncan looked at the doll Miss and sounded a bit helpless. “But since you know a lot of things on this ship are ‘alive,’ next time you want to do something, could you check with me or my First Mate first?”

Alice nodded again and again at once and answered loudly: “Yes, Captain! No problem, Captain!”

Then she quickly turned her head toward Goathead and muttered under her breath: “Is ‘failed helping’ even a thing people say?”

Goathead, for once, was brief: “Now it is.”

“All right. If you really want to help, go check the dried fish hanging on the deck, or go to the kitchen and tidy the pantry where we keep food. Clear out some space. We might get a chance to restock food on the Vanished in the future,” Duncan said with a sigh, looking at Alice. “Don’t mess with the cannons under the deck or the magazine. They aren’t like Goathead. They don’t have a full mind. Those dangerous things only react to outside stimuli on instinct. If the magazine thinks it’s being damaged or invaded, then I’ll only be able to rescue you with a broom and a dustpan.”

As soon as Alice heard that, she shrank her neck again, agreed in a rush, and turned to leave the captain’s cabin.

But watching the doll’s retreating figure, Duncan still could not help showing a small smile.

She was indeed an interesting one. A little bit of chaos was nothing. In fact, this dead-still ghost ship really had become livelier because of all her fussing up and down.

“Looks like you’re in a very good mood, Captain,” Goathead’s voice came from the side. “Ah, you’re holding something… What is that? Is it what you gained from this walk in the Spirit Realm? Like that little knife last time?”

Duncan glanced at the emblem of the Sun in his hand. He had left the liquor back in the cabin and kept the emblem with him to study later when he was bored.

“It’s a trophy,” he nodded. “Same as that ritual knife from last time.”

“Oh! As expected of the great Captain Duncan! You always come back loaded with spoils, and they are always extraordinary items that clearly hold strange power at a glance… Wait, is that a Sun charm amulet?”

“You recognize this?” Duncan raised his brows. “Yes, a Sun charm amulet. A few bold cultists shoved it into my hands—hard to refuse such enthusiasm.”

“I… do know a little…” Goathead seemed to be studying the emblem carefully, and its voice sounded slightly hesitant. “Those madmen who follow the ancient, true Sun treat such things as a sacred relic. They believe that if they cast metal into the shape of the true Sun and quench it in human blood, they can pour the Sun’s power into the sigil. With this method, they can mass-produce extraordinary items with weak power… This kind of charm amulet is a badge for Suntists who hold a certain rank. It is also what they use to confirm kin and tell Believers from Heretics…”

“Telling Believers from Heretics… it does have that function,” Duncan said with understanding. “Though personally, I don’t think that function is very useful.”

“What happened to those bold cultists afterward?” Goathead seemed to hesitate while asking this. “Most of them are stubborn, ignorant fanatics. Even the lowest pirates don’t want to deal with people who chase after ancient things like that. If they dared to offend…”

“They’re no longer in this world,” Duncan said, watching Goathead’s tone while controlling his own expression. “Seems you don’t like these people who call themselves ‘Believers of the Sun’ either?”

After dealing with Goathead for so long, Duncan had almost figured out the rules for this strange “First Mate.” He was basically sure that as long as he, “Captain Duncan,” properly held command of the ship, Goathead would not have any runaway state or strange outbursts. On that basis, Duncan’s courage in talking with it had slowly grown.

Now, he could carefully and actively ask it for some information.

“Who would like those madmen who chase the ancient, true Sun? The ‘light’ and ‘order’ they long for are no longer welcome in this world,” Goathead answered Duncan’s question as usual. “Even the Vanished bathes in the sunlight of this era. Even the Evil Spirits wandering in the Abyssal Deep of the Deep Sea would not like the ‘Sun’ from before the age of the Deep Sea—probably only that group of cultists thinks the true Sun’s revival would be a good thing…”

Goathead paused there for a moment, then added with a sigh: “But then again, ninety-nine out of a hundred of those cultists are just brainwashed idiots. They never knew what they were really following and worshiping. They treat the so-called ‘Sun Spawn’ as prophets and saviors. They long for the ancient world those Spawn describe as if it were heaven. But in my eyes, the Sun Spawn never saw those zealous cultists as their people at all… They’re no different from the Spawn in the Deep Sea.”

Sun Spawn? What did that mean? And from the sound of it, there were also Deep Sea Spawn? What were those supposed to be?!

Duncan’s heart stirred. A brand-new, strange term had jumped right into his face and brought fresh confusion. He casually toyed with the Sun emblem in his hand, acting like he was just asking offhand: “Sun Spawn? I haven’t run into them.”

“That’s normal. The Sun Spawn don’t dare appear in the civilized world just anywhere. Even if they disguise themselves as humans, the hounds of the Holy See can sniff the stink of Heresy from their shadows in minutes. In the end, they are still a kind of ‘Spawn.’ As remains of ancient things, they ought to stay obediently in history’s gutter… Sigh, among every kind of ‘Spawn,’ only they can stir up this much trouble.”

Duncan suddenly found that Goathead’s habit of rambling from time to time was actually very useful. Even if nine thousand out of ten thousand words it

said in a day were nonsense, as long as his luck was good, it could still spit out valuable information!

Since he still had not fully grasped Goathead's bottom line, Duncan could only make indirect, roundabout questions and did not dare ask too bluntly. Even so, with these indirect questions he quickly gathered many clues he had not been able to get back in the city-state of Pland—

Spawn. This seemed to be very important information. There existed some beings in this world called "Spawn," and without exception, they were not welcome in the civilized world. Goathead called them "remains of ancient things."

Those cultists who worshiped the "true Sun god" were great in number, but it seemed that most of them were just small fry—ignorant, blind, brainwashed fanatics. In their Church structure, there was a ruling class above them… those were the ones called "Sun Spawn."

The Sun Spawn did not often show their faces in the civilized world. They seemed to have hidden places unknown to the world. From there, they influenced the Sun's cults on land by remote means, secretly gathering sacrificial victims and energy.

Lastly, and this was what mattered most for Duncan right now:

Goathead held deep contempt for those cultists and for the "Sun Spawn" standing behind them.

This meant that the Vanished—or in other words, the "real Captain Duncan"—was not on the same side as these beings called "Spawn"… they should even be considered hostile to each other.

It seemed telling Goathead about his dealings with the Suntists during this walk in the Spirit Realm had been the right decision—otherwise, he had no idea when he would have learned all this useful information.

Knowledge this secret would never be written in Nina’s textbooks.

Duncan left the captain’s cabin. Holding the Sun charm amulet, he walked along the deck of the Vanished, lost in thought.

There were many kinds of Spawn. From the information Goathead had let slip—Spawn were all remains of ancient things. Together with the fact that the Suntists followed the “ancient, true Sun” from before the Great Annihilation, he had good reason to suspect that these so-called Spawn were very likely products of the Great Annihilation. Their birth might even trace back to the “Age of Order” before the Great Annihilation took place.

On the surface of the sea, there were “Sun Spawn.” In the Deep Sea, there were also “Deep Sea Spawn.”

Without noticing, Duncan walked to the rail. He leaned out and looked down at the deep, blue sea outside, feeling a bit curious.

So… the ocean was not just full of fish after all.

Chapter 54: underground sanctum

In the end, Duncan still did not understand what exactly the “Spawn” were.

Mr. Goathead was vague on this point. It even seemed that he himself did not know the true nature of those ancient things that wandered along the edges of the civilized world. As for Duncan, he could only form a rough idea from the limited clues he had—

The Spawn were products of ancient ages and held hatred toward the modern world. They had strange and dangerous powers yet hid quietly in the dark. Except for the Sun Spawn, the other Spawn almost never appeared in the civilized world. Instead, they lurked on the fringes and threatened the safety of every Explorer.

Among all this information, there was one more detail that was especially concerning:

The Sun Spawn seemed able to disguise themselves as humans—only the supernatural of the Church could tell these disguised Sun Spawn apart from ordinary people.

Duncan thought of the recent changes in the city-state of Pland, and of those believers of the Sun who had kept a low profile for years and then suddenly became loud and active again.

Were the cultists’ high-profile activities… carried out under orders from the Spawn? What were those ancient and bizarre beings plotting in the city-state of Pland?

Duncan stood at the edge of the Vanished's deck and for a long time let his gaze rest on the rolling, restless sea below.

There were Spawn in the Deep Sea as well, ancient beings different from the Sun Spawn. "They" threatened the safety of every long-distance fleet sailing between the city-states.

Duncan felt both wary and curious about these things that lived in the Deep Sea.

He believed that even though he had never dealt with them before, as long as the Vanished kept roaming the sea, sooner or later he would run into those strange beings. It would do no harm to make more preparations before that day came.

Whether it was gathering information, learning to better control his own power, or uncovering more of the Vanished's potential, all of it was planning for the future.

Of course, he was not exactly afraid of the hidden dangers in the Deep Sea. After all, he had drifted across the ocean with this ship for so long that he could roughly guess how many strange things lurked there. The Spawns were only one of countless eerie threats. As the saying went, when you had too many lice you stopped itching, and when you owed too many debts you stopped worrying. As the captain of the Vanished, there were already plenty of things out here he had to be wary of.

He pondered on the deck for a long time and realized that what he most needed to worry about right now was whether the "supply route" he had finally found would be affected. Those Spawn of the Deep Sea would not interfere with his fishing, would they?

The pigeon AI did have the ability to transport supplies, but he still did not know how much she could carry or how reliable she really was. Besides,

the city-state of Pland was an orderly place. The provisions brought onto the ship there had to be bought with money. So it was hard to say when that supply line would truly become useful.

On top of that, the rich haul from the last fishing trip was still fresh in his mind. Duncan knew very well that improving life aboard the Vanished ultimately depended on nature's gifts.

But now those "Spawn" had become a hidden danger—they might end up interfering with those gifts from nature.

Duncan felt a little troubled. He just hoped the weird things in the sea would not interfere with his fishing.

…

Bright gas lamps shone, driving away the shadows in the underground facilities of the Cathedral. Deep Sea runes carved along the long corridor gave off a reassuring power. The lines in those runes, symbolizing waves and shorelines, linked together as if weaving an invisible giant net that wrapped the underground structure of the entire building in a sacred, quiet atmosphere.

Vanna walked through the underground sanctum of the Cathedral. This holy and quiet place slowly calmed her slightly restless mood.

The storm Goddess ruled over the mightiest powers upon the Boundless Sea. Yet she did not only have the violent side that symbolized "storm". This ancient deity also commanded the power of stillness and sealing.

Just as the sea itself had two faces—calm and storm existing side by side—the Goddess's divine authority was the same. The underground of the great Cathedral symbolized the "mirror world of the Storm".

Many deities in this world were like this, with two sides or at least with two-sided traits. The Death God also held dominion over vitality, and the

God of Wisdom also possessed divine authority over the loss of reason, foolishness, and madness. Ordinary people might not know much about this, but as a high-ranking cleric, Vanna was very well-versed in such matters.

She also knew that because many deities were two-sided, this had given rise to certain very controversial, almost heretical ideas. Some scholars even believed that the entire world was two-sided. In some other dimension, they said, there might exist a “Wasted Expanse” that was a complete mirror world of the seas and lands. There, a boundless, dried-up earth stretched out in all directions, with only rare rivers and oases dotted across the drought. That Wasted Expanse might even hold an intelligent civilization strangely similar to the world of the Mortal Realm, a civilization that mirrored all things in the Mortal Realm…

Such outrageous guesses, built entirely on imagination, were of course not accepted. Even Valentine, the bishop of the city-state of Pland, who was famous for his open mind, merely snorted when he heard such talk—

In the old man’s own words, the Subspace at the bottom of this world was already enough to give people a headache. Certain folk theologians really did not need to keep hanging more things underneath the Subspace, did they?

Vanna suddenly shook her head, pulling her wandering thoughts back under control.

In the quiet depths beneath the great Cathedral, a person’s thoughts easily drifted out of control. The “mirror world of the Storm” gave people an overly peaceful mental hint. The comfort granted by the Goddess’s Sanctuary World could greatly weaken a mortal’s mental defenses. This effect was invisible yet powerful, and even an inquisitor like Vanna, who had undergone harsh training, could not fully resist it.

Yet on the other hand, this special environment also had its own special uses.

For example, it could make certain crazed, fanatical cultists open their mouths.

Vanna stopped at the end of the underground sanctum's corridor. Several doors there led to different "interrogation rooms", and a statue of the storm Goddess stood quietly in the vestibule between those doors.

This statue was different from the Goddess statue aboveground in the Cathedral. The one above had both arms spread open, as if receiving the worship of all people, surrounded by endless majesty. The one underground, however, had her hands clasped over her chest, quiet and gentle, like a maiden leaning in to perform a Listening Rite.

Yet no matter which statue it was, a veil of light gauze always covered the face. That symbolized the unknowable nature of the deity.

This statue with clasped hands for the Listening rite was the storm Goddess's other aspect: the Calm Sea Maiden.

She suppressed the waters beneath the surface of the sea and protected the peace of the Undercity.

Vanna bowed before the statue of the Calm Sea Maiden, then turned and pushed open the door of a nearby interrogation room.

The creak of the hinges broke the silence of the underground facility. When the door swung open, a spacious yet dimly lit room appeared before Vanna.

A large table stood in the center of the room. Heidi, dressed in a long black dress, was just rising from beside the table. On the other side of the table was a chair fitted with restraint chains. A heretic of the Sun sat quietly in that chair.

The heretic's eyes were dull. He slumped sideways against the armrest, as if both his reason and strength had been drained from his body, leaving only a muddled shell behind.

The heavy scent of incense still hung in the room. Heidi's medical case sat open on the table. Inside were a large empty syringe, writhing thorny vines, and a golden spike that looked as if it still carried traces of blood.

"Oh, Inquisitor Vanna, you came at just the right time," Heidi said when she heard the door open. She turned her head in greeting. "I just finished a 'treatment'."

Vanna's gaze swept over Heidi's medical case, and her expression was as calm as ever. "Honestly, I still find it hard to connect all of that with the word 'treatment'…"

"These are all standard tools for a psychiatrist… All right, I admit I probably use them more often than an ordinary doctor," Heidi said with a shrug. "But I'm a 'hypnotist' hired by City Hall who often works for the Church. The 'patients' I deal with are nothing like normal patients. Especially cultists like this—no swaying crystal or low-frequency pendulum works as well as a triple dose of 'Midnight Draught' in one shot."

"…I rather suspect the reason you always give cultists a triple dose is just that your big syringe can only hold that much," Vanna muttered, teasing her old acquaintance. Then she shook her head. "But that doesn't matter. As long as you can pry their mouths open… Tell me, what did you get?"

"I did, and I got quite a lot. The situation is strange," Heidi answered at once. "I've already performed deep hypnosis on several cultists and used some special methods. Now I'm basically certain… these cultists who took part in the sacrificial ritual most likely did not go mad only after the ritual ran out of control…"

“They didn’t go mad after the ritual ran wild?” Vanna immediately frowned. Even after speaking with Bishop Valentine, she had already understood that this matter would be more complicated than expected, but Heidi’s words still went beyond her expectations. “What do you mean?”

“I searched through their memories and found that their thinking—or rather, their way of understanding things—had already gone wrong before that final, failed sacrificial ritual even began. To be more exact, it seems those cultists were affected by some kind of… cognitive filter even before the ritual started. Because of that, in their memories… Hm? Inquisitor Vanna, you don’t seem all that surprised?”

Chapter 55: The Dinner Soup

The lack of surprise on Vanna's face did not escape Heidi. This "psychiatrist", who often worked with the Church, immediately guessed something from the inquisitor's reaction.

After a brief hesitation, she asked carefully: "It looks like… there's something very big behind this incident, isn't there?"

Vanna nodded. "Very big."

Heidi thought for a moment. While she quickly packed up her medical case, she said, "I have a day off tomorrow. I might just…"

"Heidi, you may already be connected to this matter," Vanna said, glancing at her. "I'm sorry, but everyone who was on the scene at the time, myself included, was exposed to a certain kind of cognitive corruption. The mental problems you found in these cultists actually happened to every one of us. It's just that… thanks to the Goddess's blessing, our corruption wasn't deep, so we 'woke up' by now."

"…Damn it, I knew I'd run into something like this sooner or later in this line of work," Heidi finally stopped packing the case and pressed a hand to her forehead. "I really should have listened to my father and inherited his business as an antique appraiser. Or even listened to my mother and gone to the public school in Crossroad District to be a history teacher… That would have been much safer than dealing with cultists."

"Try to look on the bright side. At least your work now lets you live a decent life in the Upper City," Vanna said, shaking her head. In front of

Heidi, who was about her age and had known her for many years, she seemed much more easygoing than she was with her subordinates. “Anyway, tell me about your findings. They might help the Church and City Hall grasp the situation.”

“…It’s actually simple. There’s one obvious wrongness,” Heidi sighed, explaining the clues she had dug out of the cultists’ subconscious. “On the night of the sacrificial ritual, a sacrificial victim went out of control before the Sun’s totem and reversed the sacrificial rite on the priest who was leading the ritual. But according to the clues we found at the scene, that ‘sacrificial victim’ who caused the runaway was actually a ‘corpse’ that had already been sacrificed once. He truly resurrected and walked up onto the platform, right?”

Vanna nodded. “Of course. I remember it very clearly.”

“Then here’s the problem… Since that sacrificial victim had already been through the rite once, why didn’t a single cultist at the scene recognize him? Leaving aside the ordinary cultists, why didn’t even that priest himself realize that the person standing before him was a sacrificial victim he had personally offered up not long before?”

Vanna slowly furrowed her brow. “…The cultists at the scene watched as a sacrificial victim who had been offered up not long before appeared again right in front of them, yet not a single person noticed the anomaly… Their memories were altered. Their understanding was twisted.”

“Even we didn’t notice that obvious wrongness at the time, did we?” Heidi said with a bitter smile, spreading her hands. “In fact, until an hour ago, I still hadn’t realized I’d overlooked something so self-evident. And only just now did I learn from you that my own mind had been affected.”

For a moment Vanna said nothing. She turned and walked over to the cultist who was still in a dazed state.

The cultist, under the double hypnosis of a heavy dose of nerve drugs and strong incense, only swayed his head slightly and stared blankly at the tall lady before him.

Vanna suddenly looked back and asked, “These cultists hacking each other to pieces after the ritual went out of control—was that also because their perception was chaotic?”

“Yes. I ‘saw’ some flickering images in their memories,” Heidi answered. “Those images seemed to burn in very deep impressions, making them firmly believe that the others at the ritual were possessed and controlled by evil spirits or something similar. They didn’t think they were slaughtering their own companions. They thought they were driving evil spirits out of the others’ bodies…”

“That was most likely their souls instinctively sounding the alarm. A cultist is still a cultist. After all, there’s a Black Sun behind them giving them ‘divine blessings’. When a huge and eerie danger appears, cultists who have received divine blessings are very likely to sense something,” Vanna analyzed from experience. “Their mad hallucinations actually revealed a bit of the truth. Unfortunately, these untrained ordinary people had no idea how to judge the meaning of those warnings and instead fell into a state of collective frenzy.”

Heidi looked at the serious-faced Vanna. After hesitating a few times, she finally spoke carefully: “So… what exactly is behind all this? Is it even more twisted than that ancient Sun?”

Vanna thought for a moment and gently shook her head. “It’s better if you don’t ask, Heidi. Your connection to this matter isn’t deep yet, but if you learn more, certain links that can’t be severed might take shape.”

“All right. If even you, an inquisitor, say so, then I’d better focus on keeping myself alive,” Heidi said as she picked up her neatly packed

medical case. “I really am going to give myself a vacation. Don’t worry, I’m not running away. In a couple of days the City Museum is going to have an exhibition on the ocean, and I’m quite interested in it.”

Vanna nodded. “Visiting the City Museum’s ocean exhibition is a good way to relax. The Goddess’s divine blessing also fills those displays.”

Heidi smiled and headed for the door with her case. But just as she was about to push it open, she suddenly stopped, turned back, and looked at Vanna uneasily. “Tell me… has the corruption really faded?”

“Relax. Of course it has,” Vanna said, spreading her hands helplessly. “We only ran into some ‘residue’. You’ve been in this quiet underground sanctum for so long that the Goddess’s divine blessing has long since cleansed away the influence on you.”

“Then I’m relieved,” Heidi finally let out a long breath and pushed the door open. “See you next time then, Inquisitor Vanna.”

Vanna watched Heidi leave the room.

Beside her, the Suntist, made groggy by the strong incense and nerve drugs, half-opened his eyes and stared blankly at Vanna.

Modern medicines, incense passed down from ancient times, the quiet environment of the sanctuary, and the “divine blessing” of the Sun deeply rooted in the soul—these tangled, chaotic forces twisted together and gathered, producing a subtle effect inside the cultist.

In the cultist’s eyes, Vanna’s figure appeared hazy and blurred.

He saw the inquisitor standing ahead, straight and firm.

He saw a vague shadowy figure standing behind Vanna. It was an almost transparent apparition, and ghostly green flames burned around it.

That tall apparition stood motionless behind Vanna, its face expressionless.

…

Duncan sat expressionless in the enchanted sea chart room, watching the doll Alice bustle about in front of him.

She was carrying a large tray. On the tray were shining, polished dishes and a big bowl of steaming soup.

From the smell, it might have been fish soup.

Clearly, after getting more familiar with the environment on the Vanished, this doll of a miss had come up with a new idea: she wanted to “do something for the captain in her own way”.

“Dinner?” Duncan looked curiously at the doll as she set the dishes and fish soup before him. “What made you suddenly think of doing this?”

“I finished organizing the pantry in the kitchen, and then I saw the… fish meat in the barrel,” Alice said, her face full of smiles and pride. “There are many jobs on the ship I can’t help with, but I can at least cook. From now on, I’ll cook for you.”

“It’s nice that you have the heart for it,” Duncan did not quite know how to judge this strange doll. Faced with Alice’s sincere smile, it was hard for anyone to say no. He was just a little curious. “But as a doll, do you even know how to cook?”

“I can learn. It feels pretty simple,” Alice said as if it were obvious. “For the basics, I just have to ask Mr. Goathead. He already told me lots and lots of things about cooking…”

Duncan, still expressionless, glanced at Goathead beside him, then at Alice.

One was a wooden carving, the other a doll made of who-knew-what. Put together, they couldn’t even make one full digestive system, yet they had

teamed up to study cooking. One actually dared to teach, and the other really dared to listen?

He had no idea what he should be feeling. He just picked up the spoon and stirred the fish soup in the bowl, thinking that at least it smelled right. But in the next second, his movements froze.

After a brief silence, he reached in and fished a long, silvery-white hair out of the spoon.

“Your hair fell in,” Duncan said, his face still blank.

“Ah, I didn’t drop just my hair in,” Alice said at once, waving her hands. “My whole head fell in… But don’t worry, I pulled it right back out. I didn’t even need anyone’s help!”

Duncan: “…?”

Chapter 56: Lower Deck

This whole thing was just too creepy, so in the end, Duncan still could not bring himself to finish that bowl of fish soup.

After all, every time he thought about the doll's head bobbing and rolling in the soup pot, he felt as if the whole dinner had gone sprinting straight toward something out of "The Grudge" and a Death God story. Even though Alice's real style was actually silly and slapstick, her head dropping into the pot like that was still a bit too horrific…

The doll looked a little hurt. She stared at the food Duncan had set aside and grabbed the lace trim at the hem of her dress with both hands: "Captain, are you angry?"

Duncan, exhausted in both body and mind, glanced at the doll: "If there's anything on the ship that makes you unhappy, you can just tell me directly…"

"Ah? I'm not unhappy at all…"

"Then try not to go into the kitc—" Duncan started to say offhand, but he quickly noticed Alice's face growing more and more downcast. In the end he could only shake his head helplessly and change his tune: "Forget it. Your intentions were good. I really am happy about that. It's just, with cooking… if you're not used to it, accidents happen. Once you get familiar with it, it'll be fine."

Alice instantly perked up: "Then I can still try again later?"

Duncan held it in for a long moment, then finally nodded: "…Just be careful."

He had thought it through. This cursed doll clearly could not stand just idling away her days on the Vanished. Maybe there really was some kind of "nature" in her that made her need to do something on this ship before she could feel at ease. And she was an independent being with her own thoughts and personality. Duncan felt he could not keep dealing with this doll only by knocking her down.

Compared to that, letting Alice help out in the kitchen was better than letting her keep picking fights with ropes, anchor chains, and cannonballs. At least the pots and pans on the Vanished had relatively better tempers.

He lowered his head and glanced at the fish soup set beside him. To be fair, the taste of the soup was actually quite normal. The seasonings on the ship were limited, but the heat had been handled perfectly. And as a doll with neither taste buds nor a digestive system, for Alice to achieve this level just by listening to a few bits of theory (and that theory came from Goathead, who also did not eat human food) was already pretty impressive.

Two beings who did not eat human food had managed, working together, to cook something a person could eat. What more could he ask for? Duncan felt that as long as this doll was more careful in the future, she really could handle work in the kitchen—at least then, as captain, he would not have to cook for himself anymore.

"Then… Captain, should I make you something else?" Alice's voice came from beside him just then, interrupting Duncan's thoughts. "I also learned how to do grilled fish and fried fish fillets from Mr. Goathead. The kitchen already has everything we need…"

"Not now. I'm not hungry," Duncan shook his head. This body of his did not actually need much food. Keeping three meals a day was mostly just to

hold on to his habits as a human. And this bowl of Alice's 'special soup' had already wiped out his appetite for half a day. He simply stood up from the table. "I'm going to walk around the cabins."

"You're going to the cabins?" Alice froze for a moment, then seemed to remember something. Her expression grew a bit tense. "Then… could you go and take a look 'down below'?"

"Down below?" Duncan frowned.

"The deeper decks—the places I'm not allowed to go," Alice said. "I keep hearing creaking sounds from down there. Sometimes it even sounds like someone is muttering under the floorboards. Maybe you could go and see… is something going on down below?"

Seeing the nervous look on the doll's face, Duncan felt his heart slowly tighten.

The Vanished's deep layers… that was the one place he had not yet explored.

The deepest part gave him a feeling that was far too strange and dangerous. Back then, he had not yet truly "taken the helm," nor had he mastered the fire of spirit form. So in his previous attempts, he had always stopped at the hatchway leading down into the cabins of the deep layers. Of course, he had planned to explore further someday—but now it seemed plans could not keep up with changes.

Just then, Goathead's voice suddenly came from the side: "Ah, sounds like the bilge is getting restless. Captain, are you going down to take a look?"

Duncan had not even spoken yet when Goathead started rambling to himself: "Now that I think about it, it really has been a long time since you checked down there. The bilge needs a bit of comfort from its captain, you know. It's been soaking in the Boundless Sea for a very long time… Will

you be taking your consecrated lantern? It’s still in the old place, just behind the door… You’ve been staying on the upper levels this whole time. The fellows down below have been noisy beyond belief. You have no idea how annoying they are. Sigh, I’m the quiet type, you see. I can’t stand those creaking sounds in the middle of the night…”

Duncan gave Goathead a silent look, and Goathead immediately fell quiet.

Truthfully, after hearing some of what Goathead had just muttered, Duncan felt even more of a resistance toward that eerie bilge. From the sound of it, the place had clearly been affected by the Boundless Sea on a deeper level and had already become a structure that counted as “wrong” even by the standards of the Vanished.

But that resistant thought stayed in his mind for less than a second.

Sooner or later, he would have to explore the other parts of the Vanished in more detail, and sooner was better than later. Reason told him that the earlier he did this, the better.

The Vanished was huge. It was not just astonishingly long; its inner hull was divided into many layers. The areas Duncan understood so far were only the upper structures of the ship—the deck, the upper cabins below the deck, the magazines and gunnery deck, and then another level below that with storerooms, the freshwater tank, and some of the crew cabins. Based on his earlier attempts, he could easily imagine how much more massive structure still lay hidden in the darkness beneath those areas.

Those structures lay below the waterline. Judging by their depth, they were completely soaked in the Boundless Sea.

Dark, grim, echoing with hollow wind or distant howls—the deeper one went, the stranger the environment inside the Vanished became.

Duncan did not truly understand his own ship—and letting that situation drag on was definitely not acceptable.

He was already this ship's captain. The Vanished was his foothold and his base of operations in this world. He could not remain so half-informed about his own foundation. Even just to survive long-term on the Boundless Sea, which was full of Anomalies and Visions, he had to understand both the potential and the dangers of the Vanished.

Who knew whether a crisis would arrive tomorrow? Who knew whether, in the very next second, the Vanished would collide with some Spawn from the Deep Sea, or with the crumbling border of a Mortal Realm?

What was more, Goathead had just mentioned something else: the bilge needed comfort from its captain.

The "captain" had stayed away from the lower decks for far too long… If this kept up, it sounded as if something bad might happen.

Duncan got up, went to the door, and found the consecrated lantern that Goathead had mentioned.

It was a very old consecrated lantern. Its copper frame was shaped like a hexagonal prism, wider at the top and narrower at the bottom. Glass panes were set into the copper frame, leaving the whole thing a little blurry. But inside that glass cover, Duncan did not see anything like a wick.

He did not show any curiosity, nor did he ask Goathead about it. After a brief and silent moment of thought, he tried to call up the ghostly green fire of his spirit form and poured that power into the consecrated lantern.

A bright green flame immediately jumped to life inside the glass. The old, simple lantern began to shed a steady glow.

Where the consecrated lantern shone, a cold, bleak atmosphere slowly spread for some reason, yet standing in that glow, Duncan felt an odd sense

of calm and control rising in him. He seemed to sense his power spreading out with the light. Everything the glow touched, every tiny detail, reflected clearly in his mind.

The dove AI suddenly fluttered over and landed on Duncan's shoulder.

It had already turned into that phantom, half-flesh, half-bone undead bird form—even though Duncan had not actively "activated" the dove at all. Under the light of the consecrated lantern, it still completed that "transformation" on its own.

Duncan glanced down at the consecrated lantern in his hand and decided this was probably a very good item. It seemed able to spread his power into the surrounding environment with very little loss and maintain a kind of "field" there. That field had the functions of detection, warning, and even control. This trait clearly made it very suitable for long-term exploration in unfamiliar or dangerous areas.

"Captain… can I go with you?"

Duncan turned and saw Alice standing behind him. She stared curiously at the consecrated lantern, her face full of eagerness. "I've never been to the lower decks! Mr. Goathead said I can't go down there without your permission…"

Duncan thought for a moment, then nodded slightly: "You can."

He still did not know what was in the lower decks, but no matter what, they were still part of the Vanished. Since he had already taken the helm, the bilge should not hold any danger that was too great. Bringing this doll along might even give him an extra pair of hands.

Goathead, left back at the chart table, did not comment. In his view, the captain going to inspect the Vanished was a perfectly normal thing—and taking along a helper was just as normal.

Outside the cabins, the veil of night was slowly falling. The cold glow of World's Wound shone on the sea, and on the empty deck of the ghost ship. The half-transparent spirit form sails billowed in the air, slowly adjusting their angle with no one guiding them.

Duncan held the consecrated lantern, carried his saber and flintlock pistol, and walked with Alice across the empty deck, through the top two levels of cabins, and down the wooden stairs toward the deep interior of the Vanished.

The staircase at the end of the seafarers' quarters was exactly where Duncan had stopped during his earlier explorations.

A strange dimness clung around the sloping stairway that led downward. In that gloom, he could only make out the supporting pillars and parts of the walls in a vague way.

"It's so dark down there." Alice stood at the top of the stairs, watching the shadowy space below with some nervousness. "Isn't there any light down here? Every other place has those oil lamps that never go out…"

"No, there is light down there," Duncan said slowly as he held the consecrated lantern. Under the power spreading from the lantern, he could finally see the space below more clearly than before. "…It's just that the light down there is black."

"…Huh?" Alice froze, needing a long moment to react. "There's such a thing as black light?"

Duncan did not reply at once. He only carried the consecrated lantern and walked down slowly. Not until Alice followed him did he speak in a soft voice: "After all, we've already gone below the surface of the Boundless Sea."

Chapter 57: Timid Alice

The captain’s words were like a cool night wind, passing down through the increasingly dim stairway. Alice instinctively hugged her arms and moved closer behind Duncan. As they went lower and lower, she finally saw what the captain meant when he said “the light down here is black.”

There really was light in the lower cabins—at least in terms of structure and layout. The cabins she saw had the same supporting pillars as the levels above, and on those pillars hung the ever-burning oil lamps. Those oil lamps were burning, yet the flames actually made the area near them darker than the places farther away.

Yes— the closer it was to an oil lamp, the dimmer the light became. The lamps themselves were almost wrapped in a layer of shadows, so that she could only faintly make out their outlines. But a little farther away from the lamps, the brightness instead began to grow. In the far corners of the cabins, the light level was almost the same as in the upper decks.

From the stairs above, the space below had looked strangely dark exactly because there were two lamps hanging on either side of the stairwell. From a visual standpoint, it felt as if those lamps were actively giving off darkness, canceling out and erasing the light that originally existed in the cabins.

Alice stared wide-eyed at the cabin that was dim overall. After a long time, she finally muttered: “This… this can’t be reasonable, can it…”

“You, an unreasonable doll, are asking me to talk about reason?” Duncan looked over at the clearly nervous Alice. “Under the surface of the Boundless Sea, the things that make sense are the most unreasonable things of all.”

When he said that, his expression was quite calm, as if he had long grown used to this kind of weirdness. But in truth, his reaction inside was almost exactly the same as Alice’s. Even the undead dove on his shoulder suddenly flapped its wings and blurted out its true feelings: “Does this make sense, does this make sense, does this make sense…”

Duncan ignored the noisy dove on his shoulder. Instead, he carefully observed this cabin he had never set foot in before, adjusting the angle of the consecrated lantern as he walked, trying to use the changes in light and shadow to read the environment.

Below the Vanished’s waterline… the light in the cabins was inverted.

The lamps did not seem to give off any light at all. Instead, they were absorbing the light that originally existed in the space, as if… they were some kind of mirror shade of the world.

Yet the spirit form glow that Duncan’s consecrated lantern released still followed the normal rules of light. It was bright around the lantern and grew dimmer as it spread outward.

What principle lay behind this? Was it only the influence of the Boundless Sea, or was it mixed with the Vanished’s own traits? Was the “bright environment” in the cabins real? If those oil lamps that “absorbed the light” were put out, would this place become bright?

For a moment, a bold idea really appeared in Duncan’s mind. He actually found himself wondering what would happen if he extinguished all the oil

lamps on this level. But in the next instant, he forcibly cut off that clearly wrong thought.

He could not put out the lights here. Even if it looked like these lights were responsible for the darkness in the cabins, there had to be a reason they were burning here.

He suddenly remembered something. In the city-state of Pland, he had learned that “burning flames can dispel eerie dangers.” In that statement, the real effect came from the flame itself, not from the light it gave off. Did that mean that, under certain conditions, light and darkness in this world could become inverted, and under that inversion, only the flame itself could be trusted?

Did this also indirectly explain why the light from electric lamps had no exorcising effect—because that was only light, lacking the essential element of “flame”?

“Captain?” Alice’s voice suddenly came from the side. The doll’s tone carried both tension and concern. “Is there some sort of Anomaly here?”

“There is no Anomaly.” Duncan’s expression did not change as he answered calmly, while slowly walking forward.

Those oil lamps that “absorbed the light” burned quietly on the pillars on either side. Some coils of rope were piled around the pillars. As Duncan walked between them, the lamps hanging from the posts crackled softly, and the ropes on the floor slowly wriggled backward, making way for their captain.

For some reason, a sentence suddenly rose up in Duncan’s mind:

Light and shadow are illusions brought by the Deep Sea. Beneath the untrustworthy surface, only the flames themselves still loyally guard the Vanished’s treasures.

He looked at the quietly burning flames and nodded slightly, as if offering his approval and thanks.

In the very next second, every oil lamp in the cabin flared up visibly. Under each glass cover, the flames leaped higher.

The entire cabin became even darker…

Duncan: "…"

He suddenly regretted praising them so early. He should have waited until he was ready to head back before giving these oil lamps any encouragement.

Alice followed behind. The doll carefully studied the surroundings. She saw huge wooden barrels and some crates stacked in the corners of the cabin, as well as some closed rooms and corridors leading to unknown places. In a low voice she muttered: "This seems like another storeroom… Was this ship once a cargo ship?"

"If it were a cargo ship, the cargo wouldn't be stored this deep—there's a thing called transport cost," Duncan shook his head and said casually. "These are long-distance supplies, meant for the Vanished itself to consume during long ocean voyages."

Alice blinked: "Long-distance supplies?"

Duncan did not answer. He simply walked forward to inspect the goods closest to him.

Some of the barrels were full of a kind of oil, dark brown and sticky, but without a very strong smell. It might have been some kind of fuel, and it had clearly been here for a very, very long time. Duncan even suspected these fuels were "stock" from before the Vanished became a ghost ship. They had probably been used for lighting or warding off evil, but after the

ship turned into a ghost ship, many things in the cargo holds ended up like this—no longer of any real use.

In another group of barrels, Duncan saw something more familiar.

Cheese older than he was. Salted meat hard enough to crack stone.

Duncan silently put the lids back on.

On this level, most areas were piled with supplies. Although a good part of them seemed useless on the ghost ship as it was now, they were enough to prove his earlier judgment about the Vanished.

This ship had at least originally been built for some kind of long-distance expedition. It could carry a huge amount of supplies, and there were strict safety measures between the various supply holds to prevent fire from spreading or pests and rats from ruining the provisions.

Thinking of the large number of cannons on the upper decks and the sizable magazines, he could almost picture the ambitious dream of exploration this ship had once carried—the farthest sea routes, the most dangerous journeys, facing the most deadly environments and the most vicious enemies. Such an expedition would need a whole ship full of loyal, skilled sailors, and a steadfast captain to see it through.

Now, however, that possible exploration plan had long since blown away on the wind. The ambitious Vanished had become the most terrifying calamity on the Boundless Sea. The sailors had disappeared without a trace, and only a ghost captain was left, still in control of this ghost ship that no longer had a goal.

He and Alice kept moving forward. After passing several separate holds, they entered a corridor. If the layout on this level matched the one above, then the stairs leading further down should be at the far end of the hallway.

“I feel… like it’s getting more and more creepy…” The doll hugged her arms as she carefully looked around and spoke in a small voice. “Do you hear the wind? How can there be wind inside the cabin?”

“I hear it. Don’t be nervous, it’s normal,” Duncan said casually. Then he glanced at the doll. “Why are you so timid? You at least have the title Anomaly 099, don’t you?”

As he spoke, he also thought of the information he had gotten from Nina before. In this world, many registers of Anomalies and Visions were open to the public. These registers helped people avoid dangers they might encounter in daily life or recognize early signs that an Anomaly was entering a runaway state. But these registers were not complete. The parts open to ordinary people only covered Anomalies and Visions whose threats were controlled, or whose nature was special enough that they might draw near to everyday life. The Anomalies and Visions that ordinary people would never have a chance to encounter in their whole lives clearly were not included.

He had tried to ask Nina about Anomaly 099, but the girl had never seen that number anywhere in her textbooks.

That meant this “cursed doll” Alice either carried some special secret, so that the authority and the Church had sealed away all information about her, or… she was so dangerous that she had always been strictly kept outside the borders of civilized society, with no chance to ever come into contact with ordinary people.

Either reason was enough to add a bit more mystery to this doll in Duncan’s eyes.

But this doll, wrapped in layers of mystery, only shrank her neck when she heard Duncan’s words. Her face was full of nerves as she said: “Having a number doesn’t make you brave. I’m Anomaly 099, not ‘Courage 099’…”

Duncan sighed. In his heart, he thought that the one in front of him was probably the most embarrassing Anomaly in the world. It was really something that the sailors who had escorted her before had managed to get so nervous over her…

Chapter 58:

Duncan had always been very curious. What was so special and dangerous about this gothic doll who called herself “Alice” that the sailors escorting her had been so nervous, and that she could still hold the title of Anomaly 099 in a world where strange and deadly things appeared one after another?

It was true that a doll that could move on its own and think clearly was already uncanny. The way she sometimes ran around clutching her head, or split herself up and acted separately, was indeed terrifying to look at. But in Duncan’s eyes, that level of weirdness still fell far short of the standard for a high-rank designation. The simplest comparison came from a piece of information he had heard from Nina:

Anomaly 196 – Blood.

It was a dangerous Anomaly sealed by containment in the underground sanctum beneath Pland Cathedral. Its true form was an amount of fresh blood equal to all the blood in an adult male’s body. This Anomaly had a certain kind of mind. It could flow and spread on its own and would actively try to replace the blood in a nearby “host” that met its conditions, seizing the body to escape. The way to stop it from flowing and spreading was to store it in twenty?two separate blood jars and keep it frozen. But if anyone bled within ten meters of its storage point, the seal failed at once. The blood in the bleeding person’s body would be replaced by Anomaly 196, and the host’s sanity would be taken over along with it.

This Anomaly ignored all countermeasures below the Saint level and would kill any suitable host without exception.

As one of the most dangerous Anomalies managed by the city?state of Pland, information about Anomaly 196 – Blood was always open to the public. That way, if the Anomaly ever leaked into the city, the authority could quickly locate it and take action.

Duncan had no idea what this so?called “Saint” really meant, but from the name alone he could tell it must be some very powerful supernatural rank. Perhaps that Inquisitor Vanna who had appeared in the newspapers was a Saint. And how many Saints like her, who might be able to fight Anomaly 196, could there even be in the entire city?state of Pland?

Yet this was only Anomaly 196, something ranked between one and two hundred. Alice’s number was Anomaly 099.

Within the top hundred.

According to Nina, there was some uncertainty in how Anomalies and Visions were numbered, and it was not always easy to compare their strength. But in general, the higher?ranked Anomalies and Visions tended to be more dangerous or stranger and harder to control. Or else they had once caused terrifying destruction or triggered some special historic event, earning their high-rank designation by being recorded in history itself.

In any case, a number within the top hundred meant bizarre properties and a level of danger that were extremely troublesome for the civilized world. It either meant the thing itself was awful to deal with, or that it had done something shocking in the past. And yet this doll named Alice, this cursed Doll…

Duncan turned and glanced back at Alice, who was honestly following behind him. She noticed the captain’s gaze at once, lifted her head, and gave him an innocent, slightly cowardly smile: “Hehe…”

There was no way to expect this one to figure out her own level of danger. He would have to look for clues later in the historical archives of the Pland city?state.

But how could an antique shopkeeper idling away his days in the Lower City ever get close to that kind of “classified information”? The “antique trade contacts” left behind by that cultist Ron were clearly useless. Most of the junk in that shop had a history no longer than last week…

Duncan thought quietly as he walked. The ghostly green fire of his spirit form burned steadily inside the consecrated lantern in his hand. Its light slowly spread deeper into the ship’s interior. The ambient light here, twisted into an “Inversion” state by the weirdness at the bottom of the hold, mixed with the glow of the consecrated lantern. Together they formed a warped, dizzying play of light and shadow.

To an outsider, this scene would probably look extremely eerie, gloomy, and terrifying.

Yet Duncan’s heart felt a faint calm. His power soaked into the glow of the consecrated lantern and seeped bit by bit, like trickling water, into the depths of this sealed?off hold. The structure of this part of the ship, which had been completely unknown to him before, slowly grew clear in his mind and sent back a subtle “sense of touch”.

The last fragment of the Vanished that was not under the captain’s control was returning to its proper track. Duncan could feel ever more sharply that, as he explored, the faint “restlessness” in the ship around him was gradually settling down.

It was just as Goathead had said. The bilge of the Vanished had been soaked in the Boundless Sea for far too long, so it had stirred up some “abnormal activity”. But as long as the captain came down in person to soothe it, the order aboard the ship would slowly return.

“You really are afraid of the seabed. Even just coming into a cabin below the sea level scares you like this,” Duncan suddenly said to Alice behind him. “So why insist on coming along?”

“I… I didn’t think that far at the time!” Alice forced herself to sound calm. “What I thought was, no matter how we walk, we’re still on the ship… I don’t even have the concept of ‘cabins below the waterline’! I’m just a doll!”

“You don’t even have a digestive tract, yet you’re studying cooking. Don’t use ‘doll’ as an excuse,” Duncan said casually. “You’ll need to study the ship’s basics properly from now on.”

Alice let out a depressed little “oh”. After a brief silence, Duncan asked curiously: “Why are you so afraid of the Deep Sea? Or rather… why are you so afraid of being ‘soaked in the sea’? I know the Deep Sea is dangerous. Many people are afraid of it, and you’ve said that before. But now it looks like… your nerves are worse than I thought. It’s already to the point that just standing in a cabin below the waterline and thinking about the seawater outside makes you jumpy… Stop tugging at the lace on your clothes. There are no spare clothes for you on the Vanished right now. If you ruin that one, you’ll have to sew it yourself.”

“Oh.” Alice quickly loosened her hands, then unconsciously started pulling at her buttons instead. “I… I never thought about it at all. I’m just scared. I can’t be scared?”

Hearing the doll’s nervous tone, Duncan did not comment. He looked toward the end of the corridor and saw a staircase slanting downward appear in his view.

That was the deeper place. It might lead straight to the bilge—the part of the ship that touched the Boundless Sea the most.

Duncan and Alice stood at the head of the stairs and looked down. By the light of the spirit flame from the consecrated lantern, they did not see any cabin structure below, but a single door standing in the darkness.

When he saw that door, Duncan frowned.

The layout here was not quite normal. First of all, the path to the bilge seemed too long. The stairways between cabins on the upper decks were connected, so one could reach each level quickly. But on this deck, the stairs leading deeper were at the very end of the corridor. You had to walk almost the entire way through the cargo area to get there. Without a doubt, this hurt the efficiency of movement within the ship.

Second, there was an extra door at the bottom of the stairs.

Duncan hesitated for a moment, then picked up the consecrated lantern and slowly walked down.

Alice hesitated even more, but in the end she obediently followed. Now she absolutely did not dare go back to the upper decks alone. Staying behind the captain was the only thing that gave her a bit of safety.

Soon Duncan reached the door. He raised the consecrated lantern and lit up the surroundings, trying to see if there were any words around the door. As expected, a line of letters on the doorframe entered his sight:

“The last door of the hold.”

“What does that mean?” Alice stared curiously at the letters on the frame. “The last door of the hold… Normally, shouldn’t the sign say what the room is for?”

“Clearly it’s a warning,” Duncan said thoughtfully as he drew back his gaze from the frame. He rested one hand on the handle and, before pushing it open, reminded the doll beside him: “If we go in and see any other doors, don’t touch them.”

Alice nodded nervously. She then saw Duncan push open this “last door of the hold” in one motion.

A strange, pale glow washed over them.

They stepped forward into a wide open space.

When she saw what lay beyond the door, Alice’s eyes widened at once: “Th?this…”

She stumbled over that “this” for a long time before finally managing to squeeze out one sentence: “C?captain! The bottom of the ship is broken! It’s broken!”

She shouted at the top of her voice, but Duncan did not answer right away. He was also staring, dumbfounded, at the scene around them.

The deepest layers of the Vanished, the bilge structure that had been soaking in the Boundless Sea—were shattered.

Everywhere he looked, the cabin was torn into pieces. Countless huge cracks and glowing voids cut through it. Hundreds of fragments of the hull floated apart in the open space, yet still kept a kind of “broken order”, preserving the outline and structure that the bilge ought to have.

Beyond the great fissures between those many fragments, Duncan could clearly see the “view” outside the bilge—

It was not the deep, dark Boundless Sea he had imagined, but a pale, murky nothingness, filled with countless obscure streaks of light rushing past at great speed.

Chapter 59:

Duncan and Alice stood at the end of the staircase leading to the bilge and faced a bizarre, chilling sight. The entire bottom of the Vanished lay in a shattered state, and beyond the broken hull stretched a kind of void filled with endless, dim light.

Was this the Vanished's true "bilge structure"? And what was that thing outside this shattered hull?

Could such a scene really exist beneath the surface of the Boundless Sea?

Duncan walked forward carefully, taking two steps into the broken cabin. He stepped onto the largest fragment of planking and looked back in the direction he had come from.

The "last door" still stood quietly where it had been, fixed onto a floating plank. Behind it lay a dark staircase slanting upward. Yet around the door, there were no walls that ought to be there. There was only emptiness.

The door floated alone in this space.

Duncan circled around to the back of the door with great care and found nothing there at all. Looking through the open doorway, he could directly see the broken cabin on the other side.

"Captain…" Alice's nervous voice drifted over. The doll looked around in fright, then finally fixed her eyes on Duncan. "Th?this… this is normal, right?"

In truth, Duncan was even less sure than the doll. At least Alice could blindly place her trust in the captain. Where was this “captain” supposed to find confidence right now? But seeing Alice so on edge, and remembering those “crew member rules” Goathead had mentioned, Duncan forced down his unease and kept his usual calm, serious expression.

“Don’t worry,” he said lightly. “The Vanished is a ship beyond anything you can imagine.”

“Yes, yes, it really is beyond imagination…” Alice said in awe. Duncan’s steady manner clearly eased her a little. She started to look around with curiosity at the broken hull and the chaotic light outside. “Captain, out there… it doesn’t look like there’s water.”

Duncan thought for a moment, then looked at Alice with sudden interest: “Do you think that outside is below the surface of the Boundless Sea?”

Alice froze: “Huh? Why are you asking me?”

Duncan’s face stayed calm: “Because you have experience.”

“That’s only because you threw me…” Alice started to blurt out, but quickly swallowed the rest and answered honestly instead: “I don’t think so… The sea should be all water. No matter how wrong the Boundless Sea is, there still has to be water under the surface. But outside it looks just like… just like…”

“A void filled with chaotic streams of light,” Duncan finished as he shook his head and slowly walked forward. He came to the edge of the plank beneath his feet and looked down at the shifting lights outside the hull. “The bottom of the Vanished… is not inside the Boundless Sea.”

Alice stared: “Huh? Then where is it?”

Duncan did not answer. He tried to look mysterious—mainly because he did not know either.

But he still had a vague guess. Perhaps this ship was actually sailing through several different dimensions at the same time. On the surface, the Vanished looked as if it was sailing on the Boundless Sea of the Mortal Realm. In truth, different parts of the ship might belong to different dimensions altogether.

That would also explain why the deeper he went into the Vanished, the more eerie and sinister the surrounding cabins became. Perhaps the truly eerie thing was not the cabins themselves…

If this dim, chaotic space outside the hull was not the Boundless Sea, then what was it? It did not look like the Spirit Realm, and it was not like the dark space he saw while crossing through the Spirit Realm either. Was it somewhere “deeper”? The Abyssal Deep? Subspace?

With countless guesses and ideas swirling in his mind, Duncan slowly drew the pirate sword from his waist. Holding the consecrated lantern in one hand and the long sword in the other, he carefully reached toward the edge of the fragment beneath his feet. He was extremely cautious now. Even though the gaps between the fragments looked small enough to jump across in a single step, he did not dare move blindly. He had to test them with the sword first.

Who knew if something might suddenly emerge from those fissures and swallow anyone who tried to cross?

A second later, his eyes widened slightly in surprise.

He saw the tip of the sword vanish. At the edge of the fragment across the gap, a piece of sword tip suddenly appeared out of nowhere.

Duncan frowned and tested in different directions. The same thing happened again and again.

He finally began to understand.

These areas that looked like cracks were actually still continuous in space. The bilge structure that seemed shattered to pieces was, in reality, still whole.

He straightened and looked around at the cracks and the flowing lights beyond them, a realization forming in his heart. The “fractured” scene was only a visual effect. It had not broken the true continuity of space. The hull of the Vanished was not really ruptured here. For some reason, the “view” outside the ship had simply appeared inside.

But what had caused that? Was it overlapping space? Or a flawed projection from a higher dimension down to a lower one?

Duncan instinctively searched through all the reliable and unreliable knowledge in his mind, trying to explain this strange phenomenon. Alice, meanwhile, watched the captain poke around at the edges of the cracks, sometimes shining the consecrated lantern everywhere, sometimes jabbing with the sword. After a long time, she finally could not hold back: “Captain… are you using a special soothing ritual to… calm the cabin?”

With his back to Alice, Duncan silently sheathed the sword and forced himself to say: “…Yes.”

“Oh! Amazing!” Alice’s eyes lit up at once. “Then are you going to perform a soothing ritual on all the fragments here?”

“…This is enough,” Duncan said stiffly, keeping his face stern. Then, before the curious doll could ask more questions, he quickly shifted her attention. “Let’s walk a bit farther ahead.”

As he spoke, he raised the consecrated lantern and carefully took a step forward. As he set his foot down, he tensed every muscle and nerve in his body, ready for anything that might happen as he crossed the crack. But nothing happened at all.

Just as when he had tested with the sword, he simply “skipped over” the process of crossing the gap. It was like walking in a normal cabin. He stepped straight onto the fragment on the other side.

Alice watched in amazement as the captain strode ahead, moving freely as if the cracks underfoot did not exist. She tried to copy him and followed. But when she reached the gap, she grew nervous again and, in the end, could not help speeding up and taking a leap…

And of course, she crashed head?first into Duncan’s back.

Duncan felt a sudden rush of air behind him, then something solid slammed into his back. His body reacted at once. He spun and swung up his arm—

The next second, he was looking with a blank expression at a headless doll behind him, flailing wildly with both hands. Alice’s head, several meters away, rolled along the planks while stammering: “So… so… sor…”

“Stay right here and don’t move. I’ll go get you,” Duncan sighed. As he hurried after Alice’s head, which was still rolling slowly away, he reflected inwardly on why he had brought this useless doll down here in the first place. He picked the head up with practiced ease. “Have you considered putting a screw in your neck?”

Alice’s head seemed not to hear the second half of his remark. Her eyes suddenly widened as she stared off to the side: “Th?th?there’s… a doo…”

Duncan frowned and looked in the direction indicated by Alice’s frantic gaze.

A pitch?black wooden door stood quietly on a fragment at the far end.

A door. There was another door. So there really was another door.

When he had seen the warning on the door at the foot of the stairs, Duncan had already wondered if this classic situation would happen. Yet when he

now saw that this “bilge space” really did contain an extra door, his heart still gave a little jolt.

Just then Alice’s body stumbled up to them. Duncan handed the doll her head as he looked toward the door: “Was there a door over there just now?”

Alice popped her head back onto her neck with a little “pop”, rolled her shoulders, and glanced that way: “I don’t think so. It only showed up after we walked over.”

Duncan answered with a noncommittal hum and, holding the consecrated lantern, carefully walked toward the door.

In truth, he no longer needed the lantern’s light in this strange cabin. The chaotic glow seeping in from beyond the cracks, though dim, was enough to give the whole space a basic level of brightness. Even so, he kept the consecrated lantern in his hand at all times. It was a necessary precaution.

Goathead had never reminded him about anything like this, but Duncan had already decided: as long as he was in a cabin below the waterline, he would never let this lamp go out.

The new door looked ordinary. Its black boards were not much different from the “last door” at the foot of the stairs, and its style and material were similar to most of the doors used on the Vanished.

Duncan lifted his head. Above the frame of this door, he saw a line of letters, as if poured in copper and set into the wood:

“This door leads to the Vanished.”

Chapter 60: The Other Side of the Door

This door led to the Vanished.

The letters on the doorframe were cast in brass and looked as if they had survived a century. Under the light of the spirit flame consecrated lantern and the hazy, chaotic glow that filled the hold, every stroke of those letters seemed plated with frozen time, giving off an ancient, mysterious air.

Duncan stared at the line of letters for several seconds, then turned away without expression.

Alice's voice came at once from the side: "Huh? Captain, are we leaving already? Don't we need to check this door? We don't have to open it, just take a look…"

"There's nothing more to see. This is already the end of the bilge," Duncan said casually.

But just then, a faint knocking sound suddenly came, making him stop.

Duncan turned and glanced at Alice behind him. Alice nervously looked around, then finally turned toward the dark wooden door: "It sounded like it came from behind this door…"

Duncan stopped where he was, his face serious as he fixed his gaze on the wooden door that the knocking had come from. He waited patiently for several seconds, then heard two more knocks. The sound was faint and

blurry, as if it came through an incredibly thick Veil, as if the door was wrapped in something invisible, but it was definitely not an illusion.

After a short but fierce struggle in his mind, he finally walked back to the door. Alice followed, crowding close, nervously watching for whatever might happen next.

Duncan held the consecrated lantern in one hand and gripped his longsword tight in the other as he studied the dark wooden door. Only then did he notice that the door was not fully closed. Along the edge he could see a gap about a centimeter wide.

The door was only pulled to, as if someone had left in a hurry and forgotten to shut it, or as if something inside had left that crack on purpose to lure the unwary in.

Duncan raised the consecrated lantern and cautiously shone it through the gap, his eyes peering at whatever lay on the other side. At the same time, he braced his longsword beside the crack, ready to stab anything that dared squeeze out.

Yet he never could have imagined what he was about to see—

On the other side of the gap was a room.

It was a small room that looked like it had been around for years. The wallpaper on the walls was dull and wrinkled. The slightly messy furniture seemed long uncleaned. Directly facing the door was a single bed. Beside the bed stood a desk with a computer, some books, and a small ornament on it.

A tall, thin figure was bent over the desk, writing quickly. The figure wore an ordinary white shirt you could buy from a street stall. His hair was messy and unkempt, and his body was on the skinny side, clearly not used to exercise.

Duncan stared through the crack, staring at the familiar scene “over there”, at that room, at the hunched figure at the desk. The figure seemed to sense something. He stopped writing, snapped his head up, and jumped to his feet, running toward the door.

The figure ran up and stared out through the crack, staring straight at Duncan.

Duncan stared back, staring at that familiar face—that was his own face!

For a few seconds they only stared at each other. Then the figure on the other side suddenly grew agitated. He began to shove the door hard, as if trying to get out, but the door did not move at all, as if it had been poured into the surrounding space. So he tried to break the lock, using tools to pry at the crack. He pounded on the unmoving door, trying every way he could to escape, but nothing worked.

The man inside finally gave up these useless attempts. He slapped hard near the gap and shouted something toward this side through the door. But from outside, Duncan could only hear vague, drifting noise, not a single clear word.

Duncan watched all of this in shock and confusion, watching the “himself” trapped in the room. He knew what the man inside was trying to do. His gaze slowly dropped to the door handle beside him.

The handle was right within his reach.

From this side, the door might be very easy to open.

Yet he only looked at the handle and did not take the next step.

The man trapped in the room seemed to grow discouraged. He shouted again toward the outside one last time. After he realized his voice could not reach beyond the door at all, he ran back to the desk, bent over, and quickly

wrote something on a sheet of paper. Then he rushed back and held the paper up for Duncan to see.

Through the crack, Duncan saw a line of messy words on the paper: “Save me! I’m trapped in this room! The windows and the door won’t open!”

Duncan suddenly laughed.

His smile slipped through the gap and fell into the eyes of the “Zhou Ming” trapped in the room. Zhou Ming’s eyes slowly widened. He looked stunned, and then gradually angry, as if feeling mocked.

The next second, Duncan’s pirate sword thrust forward, slid through the narrow crack, and stabbed straight into the body of the “Zhou Ming” on the other side.

Zhou Ming was run through by the blade. He opened his mouth as if screaming. In the blur Duncan seemed to hear a string of hoarse, chaotic sounds in his ears. Duncan did not move at all. He only tightened his grip on the hilt and pushed the sword in deeper, leaning close to the door as he said softly:

“If you can’t write Chinese, then don’t write it.”

The pigeon AI, who had been quiet the whole way, suddenly flapped her wings and let out a hoarse sound: “This is an illusion. What are you trying to hide?”

In the next second, the figure on the other side of the door began to melt like a wax statue and quickly faded into twisted, chaotic light and shadow. The room that had looked so real and so familiar shed its disguise just as fast. In Duncan’s eyes its true form appeared: a dim, old cabin, empty and bare, sealed in time and frozen decay.

The sword in his hand felt hollow, as if from the very beginning it had pierced nothing but air.

The other side of this “extra door” was only a cabin?

Duncan studied the space beyond the crack in surprise, but now, no matter how he looked, it seemed to be just an ordinary cabin.

But… was that cabin really “real”?

Duncan slowly pulled the longsword back from the crack, let out a small breath, and stepped back half a step.

The strange scene he had just experienced was still deeply burned into his mind. He did not know whether it had been a simple illusion or something else entirely. But one thing was certain. This door hid weirdness and danger far beyond what he had imagined.

If the illusion the door showed came from twisting his own memories and perception, then the danger beyond the door had already surpassed the power of “Captain Duncan”. But if it was not based on his own knowledge and memories, if some thing had “fabricated” the scene instead, then the situation was even worse.

Because in this world no one should have known what that room looked like. No one should have known that the person called “Zhou Ming” even existed.

But whatever was on the other side of this door knew.

He took a deep breath.

His caution just now had been right. No matter what, he could not open this door.

At the same time he felt a little afraid in hindsight. Just now, for a brief instant when he looked at the handle, a thought had flashed through his mind. He had wanted to open the door and let that “himself” out.

“Captain…” Alice’s voice suddenly sounded, waking Duncan from his thoughts. He looked up at the doll and saw worry and fear on the doll’s face. “Captain, are you all right? What’s inside that door? Why do you look so serious…”

Duncan shook his head: “It’s nothing. What’s behind this door is not something you should see. We’ve already reached the very bottom. We can go back.”

As he spoke, he reached out and tried to push the door, to see if he could close it.

That narrow gap really did not let him rest easy.

But the door did not budge. Even when he used all his strength, it stayed as firm as if it were fused with the very space around it.

Just like the sealed windows in his old single apartment.

Duncan pulled his hand back, thoughtful. The door could not be closed, but he certainly was not going to try to open it any further.

“Ah? Oh… oh, okay!” Alice did not pay much attention to the captain’s attempt to close the door. She froze for a moment, then reacted, her face breaking into a happy smile. “Then let’s hurry back. To be honest, this place is pretty creepy. I’m getting nervous again…”

Duncan only gave a noncommittal grunt, then turned with Alice and walked toward the “last door” that led to the stairs.

This place was far too strange. Even he did not want to stay any longer.

After that, no more Anomalies appeared.

They passed smoothly through the shattered bilge, through the cargo hold where the lighting was in Inversion, and through the dark stairs and corridors, until they returned to the cabins above the waterline.

The moment they returned to the normal cabins, Alice felt her whole body suddenly relax. It was as if some barely noticeable Shadows that had been wrapped around her had been driven away. She saw the lights around them return to normal, and the cabin no longer felt gloomy and oppressive. As for Captain Duncan beside her…

The captain looked no different from before. He did not seem to have felt the oppressive atmosphere earlier, and he did not seem to feel any special relief now. The environment deep inside the Vanished had not affected him at all.

Only, on the way back the captain was clearly very quiet, weighed down with thoughts.

“Captain, are you tired?” Alice asked cautiously. “Do you want me to make you something to eat? You didn’t really have dinner…”

Duncan stopped his thoughts and looked at the doll beside him.

On the doll’s face was genuine concern—just like Nina’s.

He suddenly relaxed, and the bit of gloom in his heart seemed to quietly fade.

“This time, don’t drop anything strange into the pot.”

“My head is not something strange!”

“Especially your head.”

“…Oh.”

Chapter 61: Unstable Voyage

Duncan took Alice back to the upper deck of the Vanished. The cold World's Wound still hung high in the veil of night.

Duncan had thought he had been exploring inside the ship for a very long time, even wondering if an entire night had passed. But looking now at the deep veil of night, it seemed he had only been down below for a few hours.

Yet the bizarre Anomalies he had seen in just those few hours were already more than enough to leave a deep impression.

He still remembered the cabin where light and shadow were in Inversion, and that door at the bottom of the ship. Especially that door. What exactly was behind it?

The consecrated lantern in Duncan's hand was already out. He and the doll walked slowly toward the captain's cabin, neither of them saying much. The doll seemed to already be running through recipes in her head, while Duncan's attention fell on the structures around the deck.

He compared what he remembered, confirming that the dim, ruined cabin beyond the door really was a part of the Vanished. The two had exactly the same style, and there was a faint continuity in their structure.

And now, thinking back, he kept feeling that there had been something else at the very deepest part of that ruined cabin, hidden in the darkness.

That was a "hidden area" of the Vanished, an area unknown even to its own captain, something Duncan could not sense or detect at all.

Did Goathead know about that door? Did it know what lay beyond it?

Should he ask it?

They reached the captain's cabin, but Duncan's thoughts were still in turmoil. He went in with Alice and saw Goathead still resting quietly on the chart table, its hollow black eyes turning toward the door at the sound.

Duncan turned to hang up the consecrated lantern, and behind him he heard Alice already greeting Goathead with some excitement: "Mr. Goathead! I went to the bilge with the captain! The bottom of this ship is amazing! The very lowest cabins are all broken apart—and there's a very strange door!"

Duncan instantly stopped worrying about how to bring up the subject with Goathead. He had almost forgotten that he had a curious, clueless doll with him. Alice's chatter had already opened the conversation for him, hadn't it?

He did his best not to laugh out loud. While he pretended to calmly tidy the room, he pricked up his ears to listen to his two "crew members" talking. Goathead's voice sounded, not at all surprised: "I knew you'd be amazed! Miss Alice, now you see what a great ship the Vanished is, don't you? It can sail in different dimensions at the same time, all while staying safe!"

As Duncan listened, his heart stirred.

Things were indeed as he had guessed. The strange scene outside the cracks in the hull at the bottom of the ship… it was because that place no longer belonged to the time and space of the Boundless Sea!

At the same time he was doing fast calculations in his heart. The curious Alice was fascinated by the strange scenes in the lower decks of the Vanished. She did not dare to ask too many questions of him as "captain", so she preferred to quiz the talkative Goathead. But if he kept standing here eavesdropping, it would look suspicious, and might even make Goathead

turn the topic toward him—if it told Alice, “Ask the captain,” he would have no way to answer…

Thinking of this, he immediately made up his mind. He straightened his expression, returned to his usual seriousness, and said calmly: “You two talk here. I’m going to walk outside for a bit. Goathead, Alice is one of the crew now. As long as it’s nothing too secret about this ship, you can tell her.”

As soon as Alice heard that, a happy smile spread across her face. Goathead answered at once, all eagerness: “Of course, Captain. Your loyal—well, you know the rest—has always treated new members warmly…”

Duncan pushed the door open and left the captain’s cabin.

But the second he stepped out, he focused his mind again. Using the close link between himself and the Vanished, he carefully watched what was happening inside the captain’s cabin.

Once he focused his mind on one place, the vague sense he had of the ship turned into clear, real-time surveillance. Everything in the captain’s cabin showed up sharply in Duncan’s mind. He “saw” Alice drag over a stool and sit across from Goathead, excitedly talking about her exploration of the lower decks of the Vanished and describing all the strange sights in the bilge.

She seemed to have completely forgotten about making a late-night snack for the captain—but Duncan did not mind at all.

He appreciated the doll’s godlike assist at this key moment much more.

Under the veil of night, AI suddenly flapped her wings and fluttered up to a nearby mast, as if to stand guard. Duncan walked slowly forward like a captain making a normal patrol of the deck, while in his mind the conversation in the captain’s cabin came through clearly.

Alice had already brought up that strange door with Goathead. The doll's voice sounded nervous: "…That door looked kind of scary. The captain wouldn't even let me get close to it…"

"Of course you can't get close. That door isn't something you can touch. Even I can't touch it—and don't give me that look, I know I don't have hands or feet. When I say 'touch', I mean in another sense… contact, control, understanding, peeking. Do you understand? In that sense, that door must not be touched. If you touch it, you're done for, got it?"

Alice seemed startled by Goathead's unusually serious tone. She hesitated for a second or two before speaking again: "Then… what is that door, really?"

Duncan, pacing on the deck, focused his mind at once. But he heard Goathead fall silent. After a long moment, it spoke in a low voice without answering directly: "You really didn't touch that door, right?"

"I didn't!" Alice answered quickly. But then she hesitated and went on, less sure: "But… but the captain went up to look. He looked through the crack, and he poked at something on the other side with his sword…"

As soon as Alice finished, Duncan suddenly felt the whole ship shudder. Then all the main sails and side sails let out a low wail in the wind, and all the masts and ropes creaked in response—and right now all of that was under Goathead's control!

He looked up in surprise at the swaying masts and rigging, as if he could feel the panic of the one controlling them through their movement. In his mind came a shout from the captain's cabin, Goathead's voice: "What did you say?! You said a crack? That door was open a crack?"

"Y-yeah…" Alice sounded frightened. "The door was only pulled to. There was a crack, about… about as wide as a finger…"

“The captain looked through the crack? And then? He also stabbed through with his sword… Did anything happen to him then? When he led you away, did he seem hesitant or dazed?”

“No,” Alice answered at once. “The captain just looked very serious, then he took me back pretty quickly. On the way he seemed to be thinking about something, but he wasn’t dazed at all. Ah, he even talked with me about cooking. I’m going to the kitchen in a bit…”

“Forget the kitchen for now! Do you know what is behind that door?”

“Ah… what is behind that door?” Alice sounded lost and afraid. She had never seen Goathead so serious and urgent before. It felt to her like the ship was about to sink.

Goathead’s tone suddenly dropped very low. It spoke slowly: “Behind that door is Subspace.”

Duncan, walking on the deck, stopped in his tracks.

Behind that door was Subspace?

He was stunned. The huge wave rising in his heart almost disrupted his monitoring of the captain’s cabin. Then another thought came to him—

The shattered bilge, the dim, chaotic turbulence of light and shadow outside the cracks there—the Vanished was sailing through different dimensions at the same time, and whatever lay outside the bilge was clearly a time and space different from the Mortal Realm. And in the bilge there was a door, and on the other side of that door was Subspace…

Could it be that the lower half of the Vanished was actually sailing inside Subspace?!

And from what Goathead said, this way of sailing did not sound stable. The bilge not only needed the captain to calm it often, but that door was also

supposed to stay tightly shut. Now there was a crack… what did that mean? Did it mean that the “sealing” of the bilge had failed? Or that something from Subspace was trying to enter the Vanished?

He remembered how he had tried to close that door before leaving the bilge. No matter how hard he pushed, the door had stayed fixed with that crack open, as solid as if it had merged with space itself.

He had not thought much of it at the time. But now, remembering it, a strange idea rose in his mind.

Maybe… when he had tried to close that door, something on the other side had been bracing against it, stopping him from shutting that passage…

Chapter 62: Interwoven Layers

It was very possible that the bottom of the Vanished had been sailing in Subspace the whole time. This shocking news made Duncan feel very complicated all of a sudden.

He had always known the Vanished was strange and dangerous, but he had never thought it was this strange. He did not know much about Subspace. He might even be less knowledgeable than Nina's history teacher. But at least he knew that Subspace was the most dangerous thing in this world. It was the "Bottom of All Things" that could keep the Saint awake at night and make the Gods deeply wary. It was so terrifying that on ships about to set sail, some superstitious sailors did not even dare to say the word "Subspace" out loud.

Even though Subspace was not a rational deity and would not turn its gaze on people just because they spoke its name, people still feared to mention that word at sea.

But the Vanished, this ghost ship that had wandered for a century, might have been sailing partly in Subspace the whole time. There was even… a door in its lower hull that led into Subspace.

The dim, ruined cabin on the other side of that door was perhaps the part of the Vanished whose structure had been completely taken over and corrupted by Subspace. And that door itself was a seal.

Duncan lowered his head without thinking and looked at the dark deck beneath his feet. His gaze seemed to want to pierce through the planks, to

see that broken cabin and the chaotic light and shadow outside it.

He suddenly felt as if he were standing on a powder keg that had already been lit. The small crack of the door was the fuse, and he still did not know how long that fuse was.

But after a brief moment of shock and tension, Duncan slowly came back to himself. Goathead's behavior seemed to reveal another piece of information.

Judging from how panicked it became after hearing what Miss Alice said, it seemed that as long as "Captain Duncan" peeped at Subspace through that crack in the door, something truly terrible was sure to happen afterward.

Even now, Goathead was still in the captain's cabin, asking Miss Alice over and over about the captain's mental state after that. It kept asking if the captain had said anything on the way back, if he had made any strange sounds, or brought out any unusual shadows.

But Duncan knew his own condition very well. He knew he was completely normal now.

The "vision" behind that door had indeed frightened him for a while. He had even, for a brief moment, thought about opening that door. But all of this was only a change in his mind. During the whole process, he had not felt the slightest touch of… "supernatural power".

That fleeting thought passed as quickly as it came, and he did not feel that the door had left any long-term effect on him.

Duncan lowered his head and looked at his own hands, silently checking himself again and again.

Here, his name was Duncan Abnomar. He was the captain of the Vanished.

In another time and space, his name was Zhou Ming. He was an ordinary middle school teacher, trapped in a small studio apartment inside the fog.

Maybe… Goathead was just too nervous? It was only a crack in the door, not an open passage into Subspace.

The Vanished rocked gently on the waves. The masts and ropes creaked. The semi-transparent spirit form sails were still a bit unstable, showing the tension and… “dereliction of duty” of the one controlling them.

Duncan looked up at the sails, then steadied his mind and spoke in a deep voice in the back of his mind: “First Mate, hold your wheel and keep the sails steady.”

“C-captain?” Goathead’s voice sounded at once, with a hint of panic. “Ah, yes! Yes, Captain!”

Duncan did not answer. He simply kept his usual silent and serious air in the mental link. He waited for Goathead to speak. Sure enough, after a few seconds Goathead broke the silence: “Captain, I just heard Miss Alice say… the door in the lower hold opened a crack…”

“Yes,” Duncan replied calmly. “I checked it.”

“You did check it. Miss Alice said you confirmed what was on the other side of the door…” Goathead seemed to be picking its words with care. “Do you feel now… I mean, any slight confusion in your mind? On the other side of that door…”

“Subspace, I know,” Duncan cut him off before Goathead finished. “Do I look out of my mind to you right now? Do not talk in such a roundabout way.”

“Of course, you look completely without any anomaly!” Goathead said at once. “Maybe I am just too nervous. After all, this has never happened before. Ever since you sailed the ship back, the barrier between the

Vanished and Subspace has always been stable. I… did not expect the situation to change. This is by no means doubt toward you."

Sailed the ship back? Back from where?

Duncan caught the information hidden in Goathead's words at once and quickly guessed a bit of the truth. But he did not show any reaction. He only said, as if in passing: "From what I can see, the crack in the door is still stable for now, but it may grow wider. I want to hear your thoughts."

"…If it is stable now, that is already good news, Captain," Goathead said, not suspecting anything, but sounding very worried. "As for my advice… to be honest, I do not know what to do. You left that door there with your own hands, and you closed it with your own hands. You never told me what plans you had afterward, and you never said what changes might follow. You have always handled everything in the lower hold yourself…"

"…Right," Duncan followed along at once. "You probably have no advice to give on this."

It seemed Goathead also did not know the full story about the door in the lower hold.

It only knew that on the other side of that door was Subspace, and that nothing good would happen once the door opened. More information… was actually in the hands of the "real Captain Duncan".

But where was he supposed to find the "real Captain Duncan" now?

"Captain…" Goathead's voice sounded in his mind again. "Do you have any plans for what comes next?"

Plans? What plans? Was he supposed to run onto land? With Captain Duncan's reputation as the enemy of the whole world, the Vanished would probably draw an entire fleet to hunt it down the moment it appeared near

any city-state. Other than drifting on the sea together with this ship, what else could he do?

Duncan rolled his eyes and tilted his head back helplessly to look at the sky. AI, who had flown up to the mast earlier to pretend to stand guard, now flapped down and landed on his shoulder. The pigeon bobbed its head and squawked: “It is a trap! Abandon ship and escape!”

“Escape? Escape my ass…” Duncan blurted out. Then he suddenly realized something. “Wait, you can hear my conversation with Goathead?”

He had been talking with Goathead through the mental link the whole time. Why had this pigeon suddenly flown down just to say something that fit the moment so well?

The pigeon flapped its wings and looked very full of itself: “Damn it, do not talk. I have my own understanding!”

Suddenly, Duncan felt a little curious about what pigeon soup would taste like.

But he had not forgotten that Goathead was still waiting for him to speak. After steadying himself, he ignored the pigeon on his shoulder that clearly needed a good boiling and went on speaking in his mind: “Just do your own job. I will keep an eye on that door from time to time, as always.”

“Yes, Captain!”

The Vanished slowly steadied. The sails adjusted their angle again, letting the huge ship keep moving forward on the Boundless Sea.

The bow cut through the waves. Fine spray slapped against the hull with a rushing sound.

After ending his talk with Goathead, Duncan walked slowly to the edge of the deck and looked down at the dark sea beneath him.

The water reflected the cold, pale glow of the World's Wound.

He would keep an eye on the door in the lower hold, but simply "watching" that door would not change anything.

He needed more knowledge. He needed to understand and control his power further. Maybe… he also needed some help.

The ship did not have these things. The city-state of Pland might.

Tomorrow, Nina would come back from school. In the days after that, she would return to the antique shop every day after class. Her "Uncle Duncan" would have to be in the shop then.

Before that, he had to move his "main consciousness" back into the city-state. Until he could skillfully control two bodies at the same time, this kind of frequent switch in viewpoint was his only choice.

While making the transfer this time, he also had to let AI run some further tests.

He wanted to see if AI could bring things from the Vanished to that antique shop. If she could, he needed to find out whether there was a limit to what she could carry, and whether "packets" would be dropped if she carried too many items…

All kinds of plans brewed in his mind. At the same time, Duncan let his eyes roam over the rolling waves outside, as if he were casting a gaze on the sea.

The reflection of the World's Wound in the sea looked hazy and chaotic. The scattered pale light was like formless streams of light.

The World's Wound?!

Duncan froze. He suddenly felt that the sky reflected in the sea looked vaguely familiar.

He jerked his head up and looked at the huge crack in the sky, like a wound.

Inside that giant “wound”, dim, chaotic light flowed. Around the wound, the sky was filled with drifting luminous mist. Looking closely, that so-called mist was actually made of countless overlapping, tangled, blurry streams of light.

Just like… the scene outside the broken cabin at the very bottom of the Vanished.

Chapter 63: Return to Port

Duncan kept his eyes fixed on the huge wound in the sky, which gave off a dim glow. It was as if he wanted to find some detail he had seen before in the chaotic flowing light and mist, to prove the shocking guess in his mind.

Was the scene outside the bottom of the Vanished the same as the World's Wound?

If what lay beneath the ship's bottom was Subspace, then was the World's Wound also a part of Subspace? Or at least connected to it in some way?

But in the end he could not see any clues, and the guess in his mind could only stay a guess.

The wound was far too distant. Even if he took out a spyglass, he could not see any more details. From what he could see now, it only looked a little bit like the scene outside the bottom of the Vanished. Rather than saying the two were the same, it was more likely that his nerves were too tight after exploring the lower hold, so he saw danger and connection in everything.

Duncan stood on the deck in the sea breeze for a long time. He thought while he let his mood slowly calm down. He also paid attention to Goathead's side and saw that his "First Mate" seemed to have calmed down as well and was now carefully steering the Vanished.

But Duncan could still keenly feel a vague tension spreading over the ship. This tension seemed to have no single source and soaked into the whole "living" ghost ship. The tall masts, the crossed sails, the ropes piled on the

deck… these silent things in the dark all seemed to be whispering nervously and heavily to each other, talking about “that door”.

This was the first time Duncan had directly sensed the emotions of the “ship” in his mind.

It seemed that after he came back from the lower hold, his bond with the ship had grown deeper.

Now the entire ship was watching the captain, watching for any anomaly in him after he had peeped at what lay beyond that door.

The evening wind blew against his face. Duncan took a deep breath and slowly walked toward the captain’s cabin. His fingers tapped lightly on the rail by the side of the ship as he said, almost as if talking to himself: “Relax, this matter is nothing special.”

This time he clearly felt the change. The tension that filled the ship slowly faded. The ropes were no longer taut. The sails lifted with more spirit, and even the faint creaks from under the deck gradually died away.

It seemed the ship had finally confirmed that the captain was still the captain.

Duncan came back to the door of the captain’s cabin. But instead of pulling it open and walking in as usual, he hesitated a bit, took hold of the handle, and pushed the door inward.

The door opened. Inside was a mass of rolling black mist.

Duncan stepped toward the black mist. The pigeon AI, who had still been resting on his shoulder, suddenly flapped her wings and flew to a mast not far away, crying as she went: “Road ahead closed, road ahead closed!”

Duncan looked curiously at the pigeon that had suddenly fled, but still took one more step forward.

He returned to his familiar studio apartment.

Zhou Ming lowered his head and checked his body at this moment: familiar hands, familiar shirt, familiar trousers. He was not as strong as Captain Duncan but just an ordinary human being.

Then he lifted his head again and looked around the room.

Everything was exactly the same as when he had left. There was not even more dust.

Zhou Ming looked thoughtfully at the furniture in the room. Then he suddenly turned his head toward the door. He looked at the door of his studio apartment and recalled the door he had seen in the lower hold of the Vanished, remembering the position and angle of that crack.

He stood in the matching spot, first imagining that someone was standing on the other side of the door. Then he looked in the direction opposite the door.

From the crack in the door, one could indeed see the center of the room and the somewhat messy desk there. On the desk sat a computer and other odds and ends. He usually worked at that desk, reading and writing or grading his students' homework and test papers.

Zhou Ming slowly opened the door a crack and bit by bit moved his eye up close to it.

At that moment, he felt his heart pounding. His reason told him that his thoughts made no sense, but he could not help thinking… would an eye suddenly appear on the other side of the crack? Would a ghost ship captain with a gloomy, stern face suddenly appear? Would a pirate sword suddenly stab in?

He pressed closer and peered outside.

Outside there was only rolling, surging black mist, just like always.

Zhou Ming let out a sudden sigh of relief. Yet for some reason he also felt a weird sense of loss, as if his expectations had been dashed and he had missed out on some fun.

He shook his head hard, throwing off that strange mood, and then slowly walked to the desk. Everything he had left in the room before leaving was still there, including the scrap paper covered in random doodles, the neatly arranged journal, and the computer screen that still glowed even though the power had been cut.

It seemed that nothing had changed.

Zhou Ming exhaled, but suddenly his expression froze.

There was a change!

His eyes locked on a corner of the desk. In that unremarkable spot, there was now a small new object. It was an extremely delicate ornament, a lifelike model, a ship… the Vanished.

Zhou Ming felt as if lightning had struck him. He sat frozen in his chair for a full half minute. He was a hundred percent sure that this ornament had never been on his desk before… especially since the ornament was a “model” of the Vanished!

After a long time, he finally blinked and reached out to carefully pick up the “model” that had somehow appeared on his desk. He held it in his hands and examined it closely in front of his eyes.

This lifelike “ghost ship” was only a bit more than half a foot long. It weighed about the same as any ordinary model in his hands. Yet it was so detailed. Zhou Ming studied it for a long time. He could even see every rope and every bucket on the deck…

Compared with the real Vanished, the only difference in this ship might be its size.

All of a sudden, Zhou Ming seemed to think of something. He brought the ship closer to his face and carefully “pried” open the door of the captain’s cabin at the stern with a fingertip. He peered through the tiny doorway and searched inside.

On the tiny chart table inside, he could not see any sign of Goathead.

Likewise, he could not see Alice anywhere on the ship.

Zhou Ming felt a strange feeling rise in his heart. He did not know why he had thought that “Alice” would show up on this miniature version of the Vanished. That was clearly far too ridiculous.

Maybe it was the appearance of this ship itself that was too ridiculous.

Zhou Ming held the tiny Vanished in his hands and thought for a very long time.

He did not know how the ship had appeared on his desk, but it was clear that the link between his sealed-off studio apartment and the “world beyond the door” was deeper than he had thought.

The change might have happened after he began “steering” the ship. It might also have happened after he peeped at Subspace through that crack in the door.

He leaned back against the chair and let his mind slowly grow calm.

He found that he could still “feel” what was on the other side of the door. He could feel the Vanished and feel Goathead. He could even… feel the distant city-state of Pland and the other “body” in that antique shop.

He did not know how long he stayed lost in thought like this before he suddenly blinked as if waking up. He looked at the ghost ship still resting in

his hands, then looked at an empty shelf at the far end of the room.

He had bought that shelf years ago, but until the Visions came, he had never found a chance to fill it. Now there were only a few decorative crystal bottles he had been tricked into buying online. All the other compartments were empty.

Zhou Ming carried the Vanished over and carefully set the delicate “model” on the shelf.

After placing it, he stepped back two paces and carefully looked at his “work”, seeming quite pleased with the spot he had chosen.

How this thing had appeared here was still a mystery. But at least… in these days of being trapped, he could decorate his little home a bit more.

…

A loud, long steam whistle broke the calm on the sea. Vanna, who had arrived early at the Harbor, walked at once to the edge of the lookout tower and gazed toward the docks.

The entire Harbor had been cleared ahead of time. The once busy main port of Pland was now empty. There were no ordinary loading workers or clerks on the docks anymore. In their place stood fully armed constable units and Guardians from the Church.

Twelve Steam Walkers blocked all roads leading into the dock area.

Out on the water beyond the harbor, between the gently rising waves, a handsome steam-powered ship was slowly drawing closer.

The White Oak.

Chapter 64: The White Oak Ran Into Duncan

The White Oak had returned. After a long loss of contact and a drift off The route, this advanced steamship under the Explorer Association finally came back to the city-state of Pland.

Many people had been waiting for this ship to come home. Countless eyes stared at the silhouette that slowly drew closer over the sea, watching it with tense, almost gaze.

Inquisitor Vanna saw that, as soon as the White Oak's whistle sounded, the people on the pier moved at once.

The workers in charge of mental guidance for docking ships were already in position. They began to send signals to the White Oak with lamps and flags. Guardians under the Church went to activate the Deep Sea sacred relics that had been placed all over Pier One the night before. These were many bronze Boundary Stele. The base of each stele was carved with the name of the storm Goddess Gamona, and the groove at the top was filled with holy oils and spices. Once these Boundary Stele were activated, the area where the White Oak would dock would be sealed off and become a "Sanctum" under the Goddess's gaze.

Farther back stood Constables sent by City Hall. These ordinary people were not good at dealing with supernatural things, so their main job was to use heavy firepower to block every intersection. Ordinary guns and cannons could hardly deal with strange, shapeless curses. But if something with a

solid body, something already under corruption, ran off the White Oak, then eight-millimeter bullets and four?pound guns would still be very useful.

Sometimes Vanna could not help feeling grateful for the progress of technology. These fruits of engineering gave weak, powerless ordinary people at least some strength to take part in events that involved the supernatural. The results of that progress were mixed, good and bad, but at least… support from rotary machine guns and artillery had greatly reduced the Church's casualties in these past years.

Vanna's gaze passed over the pier and went to the distant sea.

The White Oak let out a second blast from its whistle. Guided by the Light-Signal lamps on the shore, the ship began to slow. It then stopped at a distance from the pier.

A priest standing beside Vanna finally let out a small breath and said in a low voice: "The White Oak followed the order. It looks like the ship is still under 'human' control, at least."

"We cannot say that yet. Many people under the influence of an Anomaly or Visions still looked normal until the very moment they changed," Vanna shook her head. "Send the second set of signals. Dispatch the inspection boat. Tell the Coastal Guns to stay ready at all times. As soon as anything strange happens on that ship… open fire."

The order from the Inquisitor spread down the chain very quickly. Since the White Oak's communication device had already been damaged, the people on shore could only talk with the ship by lights and flags. After a complicated exchange of lamps and flag signals, three lights lit up at the bow of the White Oak. Right after that, a rope ladder dropped down from her side.

A small fast boat left the pier and rushed toward the White Oak, driven by a small Steam Engine.

A full Guardian squad rode that boat. It included eight combatants, one Commander, and one Deep Sea priest. These loyal Clerics lit incense on the small boat and chanted the holy name of the storm Goddess. When they came close to the White Oak, they did not board right away. They first circled once around the big ship and sprinkled Holy Oil mixed with seaweed extract into the nearby sea.

Once these oils fell into the sea, they began to glow faintly at once. The light slowly spread and joined together, until it formed a ring that fully wrapped around the White Oak.

Only after all this did the Clerics on the boat truly move in close to the White Oak and climb aboard along the rope ladder.

All of this fell into the eyes of Vanna up in the watchtower.

Letting a ship that had once gone missing at sea “come home” was extremely dangerous, especially when it was a long-range ship that had carried Anomalies. The White Oak could not come alongside the pier directly. First, it had to accept a boarding inspection from the small boat at a safe distance. Only after the first check showed no clear sign of corruption by an Eldritch God could it move closer to Pland’s pier. Even then, the people on the ship still could not disembark. They had to undergo a second round of checks by the Clergy. At the same time, the whole ship would face a much stricter, complete search and purification. After that, everyone on board would still have to stay under observation in the Cathedral on the pier for several days at the least, or several weeks at the longest. The entire ship also had to be fumigated with incense and purification for at least a week.

Only when all these steps were finished, and nothing went wrong at any point, would the civilized world dare to welcome these people who had

gone astray at sea back home. If any step went wrong, the White Oak and her crew members would have to be buried in the ocean.

The storm Goddess would receive the souls of these poor people.

This rule, cold to the point of cruelty, did not come from anyone's malice. It was the "way of survival" that human society had found after growing to this day.

Of course, there were also city-states that did not want to follow, or failed to follow, these harsh rules. Most of those city-states now appeared in the first two units of the second volume of the middle-school history textbook and were standard questions on the final exam.

Time passed second by second. Everyone waited for the Guardian squad that had boarded the ship to send back a signal. There were only two possible signals. If everything was safe, the squad would send a docking request through special Psychic Communication. If the ship had already fallen to corruption, the squad would fight until the last person and try to blow up the Nitroglycerin on their small boat before they all died.

On an Ocean-Going Vessel the size of the White Oak, if it really fell under deep corruption by Subspace or something like it, a small boarding party like this could not possibly come back alive.

Vanna crossed her arms and tapped lightly on the metal of her arm guard.

All of a sudden, the bell in the small Cathedral on the pier began to ring. The steam relief pipes on both sides of the bell tower let out three long blasts.

The priests in the Cathedral had received the coded message from the inspection squad. The Cathedral's bells and whistle blasts now told every group on the pier:

The ship was safe. The White Oak was asking to dock, and there was a special situation to report.

Vanna finally let out a breath.

At least for now, that ship seemed normal. That alone was the best news.

As for the “special situation” to report… she was not surprised at all.

A ship that had gone missing in such a strange way coming back into port, and there was nothing special to report? That would have been the truly strange thing.

The White Oak slowly drew alongside the pier. This long-range ship that had gone through so many twists and turns finally came back to the pier of the civilized world. The people on board had not been allowed to disembark yet, but they could surely relax a little now.

More Church Guardians began to board in an orderly way to prepare for a full search and questioning. Vanna also left the watchtower. She personally led a group of priests down to the pier. She walked across the long gangway and finally set foot on the deck of the White Oak. There, on the foredeck, she saw the tall, broad-shouldered captain with graying hair.

The old captain looked a bit worn out. It was clear he had been working under heavy stress for too long. But when he saw the Church’s Inquisitor coming closer, the old man still straightened at once and stepped forward to meet Vanna.

“Hello, I am Inquisitor Vanna of the Deep Sea Church of the city-state of Pland, Captain Lawrence,” Vanna said. She did not like empty formalities, so she chose to get straight to the point. “Let us skip the self-introductions. First, I must apologize. I hope you and your crew members can understand these strict checks by the authority of the city-state and the Church.”

“Of course, Inquisitor,” Lawrence nodded at once. He had wanted to say “Inquisitor miss,” because Vanna looked about the same age as his own daughter, but at the last second he changed it to the more respectful title. “I expected this long ago. After all… we were out of contact for so long.”

Vanna nodded: “Tell me briefly what the White Oak went through. Why did you lose contact? And why did you later show up on an unregistered route? As for the cargo you were escorting, Anomaly 099, what is its status?”

At these words, Lawrence’s face filled with dismay and tension. He sighed and, almost without thinking, glanced quickly around. Only then did he speak slowly: “You may not believe this. We… ran into that legendary ship, the Vanished…”

Right in front of him, the stern-faced Inquisitor miss suddenly froze like stone. A strange expression fixed on her face.

Lawrence could not tell what this expression meant. To him, it looked almost the same as how he had felt a few days ago after being rammed by the Vanished.

“Inquisitor… ma’am?” Lawrence asked carefully. “You…”

“Captain Lawrence,” Vanna seemed to wake up all at once and stared hard at the captain. “Say that again.”

“I said you may not believe this…”

“The second half.”

“We ran into that legendary ship, the Vanished…”

“I believe you.”

Lawrence blinked: “Then…”

“You and your people may have to stay at the pier a few more days, Captain,” Vanna said with a very serious face. “This matter is serious. Very serious. You… wait. You ran into the Vanished, and everyone still lived?”

The Inquisitor miss’s expression shifted a little. A hint of doubt appeared in her eyes. Seeing this, Lawrence quickly spread his hands: “Our people are fine. But the Vanished took Anomaly 099. That is the Doll spirit coffin. I suspect that ghost ship came for the Doll spirit coffin.”

“The Vanished took Anomaly 099?” Vanna frowned. Then she asked: “And after that? It just let you go?”

“Y-yes,” Lawrence grew nervous as well and faintly felt he had guessed something. “Inquisitor, recently in the city… did something happen…”

“…There is no harm in telling you, since it now seems your ‘contact’ may be deeper than ours,” Vanna sighed and looked at the old captain. “Captain Lawrence, you may not be the only person who has dealt with the Vanished lately. Let us find a quiet place. I need to know more.”

Chapter 65: Guillotine

The captain’s cabin of the White Oak had been turned into a temporary Sanctum.

The smell of incense drifted through the room. charm amulets painted with Storm Runes hung on every door and window. priests had also placed bronze Boundary Stele in the four corners of the room and tied strips of cloth soaked in Holy Oil to the tops of the stele. Last of all, a copy of the Storm Canon from the great Cathedral was brought into the room to serve as the “pillar” of the Sanctum.

Only after all these arrangements were complete did Captain Lawrence and Inquisitor Vanna enter the cabin together.

“I hope you do not mind this ‘remodeling’ of your room,” Vanna said calmly. She kept the reserve and proper manners that suited a high-ranking Cleric. “It is all for safety.”

“Of course. All for safety. Right now, safety is exactly what I lack the most,” Captain Lawrence nodded in full understanding at once. He looked around at all the holy objects in the room and felt himself relax a little. “With all these here, ordinary twisted things of corruption would probably die just from stepping inside and taking one look…”

“You can feel at ease talking with me about the Vanished in here,” Vanna nodded. “Start from the very beginning. Where did you see that ship, and how did it appear?”

Captain Lawrence took a breath and began to calmly retell the most terrifying day in his memory: “It was like this…”

Captain Lawrence spoke in great detail. In front of a professional Inquisitor, he even told her exactly what he had eaten for breakfast that day and the exact time the sailors had started their meal. For the parts he truly could not recall, he turned to the captain’s log and the sailors’ journals for that day.

Experienced captains all knew one thing. Before many Anomaly events fully appeared, there were often signs that seemed ordinary. At the time, people might find it hard to see the links between these things. But later, professionals looking back could find clues in those daily details and draw lessons to warn others.

Every captain on the Boundless Sea kept a log of the voyage. At the same time, reading one’s own log was, besides reading Church classics, the only safe “reading” on the Boundless Sea.

When Vanna finished listening to this shocking account, her bold brows had slowly drawn together.

The situation was more serious than she had thought, and also stranger than she had thought.

She had first believed that when Captain Lawrence said “we ran into it,” he meant only a brief encounter, or at most that they had brushed past that ghost ship. In that case, the terrifying captain of the Vanished might have only taken the cargo and left the crew unharmed. She had never expected that it had actually been a direct collision.

The whole White Oak had crashed right into the hull of the Vanished. The whole ship, from top to bottom, had been swept over once by that green ghostly flame.

According to Captain Lawrence, at that time the White Oak had even started to transform into the Vanished. He had clearly seen his own body shifting into a spirit form state.

The Holy beacons on the ship had been shut down. The sacred relic in the hold had not reacted. The defensive materials added into the hull had done nothing. The priests could barely protect themselves. The whole ship had sunk deep into the Spirit Realm and could not send any call for help to the outside. It was fair to say that, at that moment, the White Oak had already become that captain's prey. There had been no chance for any "lucky escape."

The only reason Captain Lawrence could still stand here now was that the Vanished had given up this prize without hesitation.

"Inquisitor," after he finally finished his story, Captain Lawrence could not help speaking when he saw that Vanna stayed silent for a long time. "What do you think the Vanished was trying to do back then? Did it really only want Anomaly 099?"

Vanna looked at him: "Was that not what you always thought?"

"I… I did always think that, but now I am no longer sure," Lawrence sighed. "Especially after you just said that ghost captain recently stretched his power into the city-state of Pland… I keep feeling it cannot be that simple."

"No one can guess what that ghost captain is thinking," Vanna shook her head. "All we can do now is carry out the most thorough checks on the White Oak to keep it from bringing in any 'intruder.' You and your crew members will also have to suffer some hardship. Before the investigation is over, you may not meet with anyone except Church priests… including family visitors."

Captain Lawrence lowered his head: “I understand.”

He paused for a moment, then added: “Then… about the theft of Anomaly 099…”

Vanna knew what the captain was worried about.

The strange, terrifying Visions on the sea hung over civilization as a threat. But before thinking about such distant, great dangers, this captain was first a normal man who had to feed his family. Losing Anomaly 099 was a burden too heavy to place on an ordinary person.

“Do not worry. The Church will report this matter to the city-state authority and the Explorer Association,” she said in a calm voice. “The appearance of the Vanished counts as force majeure. The loss of Anomaly 099 is not your fault. Even if a Cathedral ship had been in charge of the escort that day, the result would likely have been the same.”

The expression on Captain Lawrence’s face clearly relaxed a little.

Yet there was one thing Vanna did not say aloud. In the end, Anomalies always walked the line between sealing and a runaway state. Every year, new Anomalies lost control. City-state residents died under the influence of strange things again and again. For hundreds and thousands of years, the Church had fought these Anomalies in their runaway state. In this long, huge balance of terror, the loss of a single Anomaly was not impossible to imagine, even if its number was under one hundred.

But as an Inquisitor, she could not say such things.

“Also…” At this moment, Captain Lawrence broke the silence again, though he sounded a bit hesitant. “I would like to ask… what exactly is so special about Anomaly 099?”

He paused there, then quickly added: “Of course, when I took the escort job I did receive a file, but it mostly covered how to keep Anomaly 099 sealed

and how to handle it in the first stage of a runaway state. It did not say anything about where this Anomaly came from or what would happen in a full runaway state… You know, it is an Anomaly numbered under one hundred. The more ordinary people around it know about it, the more likely it is to go into a runaway state. I do understand that rule.

“But now Anomaly 099 has already been taken by the Vanished. By the rules, it should now count as fully in a runaway state, so…”

“I can tell you,” Vanna said with a nod before Captain Lawrence could finish. “Anomaly 099 has already left the control of civilized society. By regulation, its data will be shared with the Adventurer Association and the supernatural teams of the city-states to help capture and reseal it later. You are a member of the Adventurer Association and the last person to come into contact with Anomaly 099, so you should know this information.”

She stopped to think for a moment. Then, as she sorted through what she knew, she spoke slowly: “Anomaly 099, Doll spirit coffin. On the outside, it looks like a fancy wooden box, like a spirit coffin. Inside it is a Doll in a sleeping state. The Doll has silver hair and a purple dress. Her body is similar in size to a human.

“This Anomaly was first found in the northern Frost Sea. The Doll inside looks almost exactly like Ray Nora, the queen of Frostholm who was executed by Rebel decapitation about half a century ago. But there is no clear proof that links the two.

“This Anomaly has no will of its own. It has no mind. But it is very likely that, driven by instinct, it will actively sense the outside world and affect it.

“You should already know the sealing method for Anomaly 099, so I will not repeat that. As for its danger…

“First, the Doll spirit coffin has a ‘settling’ tendency. Once it stays for a long time in one area, it will treat that place as its own territory. After that, it becomes very hard to move it again. It will start to spread its influence in its settled place. At the same time, the strength of the seal will quickly weaken and it will become easier and easier for it to enter a runaway state. This is also a shared trait of quite a few Anomalies. Because of this, Anomaly 099 must be moved and resealed often to keep it from overgrowing.

“Next, when the Doll spirit coffin is in a runaway state, all humanoid beings within a certain range around it will be used as test targets. That includes humans, elves, Senkin, and gyproans. This range can be as short as a hundred meters or as long as nearly a thousand. It will grow with the time Anomaly 099 has ‘settled.’ The exact check standard is still unclear. What we do know is that whoever is chosen as a target will at once lose control of their body like a Puppet on strings. They will then move without knowing it, kneel, and bow in the direction of the Doll spirit coffin, just like city-state citizens bow to their Queen. As soon as this action is complete… the victim is decapitated on the spot.

“This decapitation cannot be dodged, blocked, or resisted. Any blessing on the victim or any armor they wear is useless. The only condition is that ‘the Doll has chosen you.’ Once the victim finishes the action, they will be in a state as if they have already been decapitated. After the decapitation, the Doll will stay quiet for four to six hours. Then it will start looking for the next target, until no one is left alive in range or the spirit coffin is sealed again.

“When the Doll spirit coffin is in a runaway state, it can move. Its speed is very fast and its strength is very great. It will break free from capture in all kinds of shocking ways. The spirit coffin itself is also very tough. So once it goes into a runaway state, its danger grows even further.

“In the several runaway state events of the Doll spirit coffin, only one Saint lived through it. But that Saint happened to have the bloodline of the northern city-state of Frostholm. Because of that, we cannot tell whether it was the Saint’s power that stopped the curse, or whether his bloodline simply met the Doll spirit coffin’s ‘pardon’ condition.”

While he listened to the young Inquisitor’s calm and smooth explanation, Captain Lawrence felt the hair on his body stand up one by one.

His first thought was: the authority’s money was truly not easy to earn!

No wonder the pay for escorting Anomaly 099 was almost five times the pay for escorting normal Anomalies. This kind of deadly power ignored defense and dodging, and it only needed the condition “the Doll has set its eyes on you” to take effect. On an Ocean-Going Vessel where there was no way to run, it was almost a sure thing that once it entered a runaway state, everyone on board would die.

Only the captains in the Explorer Association, who specialized in “extreme survival,” would take on a job like that.

At the same time, he heard Inquisitor Vanna’s voice continue: “Because of such strange and terrible power, when the Church filed Anomaly 099, it gave this ability a special name. The name came from the tool used to execute the Frostholm queen by Rebel decapitation half a century ago:

“Alice Guillotine.”

Chapter 66: A Beautiful Morning on the Vanished

“Alice! Watch your head!”

The beautiful morning aboard the Vanished began with the captain’s powerful shout echoing across the deck.

Duncan stood outside the captain’s cabin, pointing at a doll’s head hanging from a nearby beam. The corner of his eye twitched for a long moment before he finally saw a doll’s body in a deep purple Brother long dress scramble up from the side and hurriedly take down the head dangling in midair.

With a crisp “pop” in the air, Miss Doll snapped her head back in place, then trotted over: “Hehe…”

“Hehe what? What are you ‘hehe’-ing about? Why did you hang your head at my door first thing in the morning?” Duncan glared at the cursed Doll, who liked to pull tricks every few days. To be honest, if anyone opened their door early in the morning and saw a head drifting in the breeze at the threshold, they would jump out of their skin. It was only because he had been on this ship long enough, and his nerves were tougher than before, that he didn’t faint on the spot. “And don’t tell me you were on lookout – we have a pigeon for that.”

“I washed my hair this morning…” Alice hunched her neck and answered carefully. “It just wouldn’t dry, so I thought I’d hang it up higher to let the wind blow on it…”

Duncan: “…”

Alice peeked at Duncan nervously: “Captain… are you mad?”

“You… are reasonable.”

Duncan held it in for a long time before he could squeeze out that line. While he fought the twitching of his facial muscles, he had to admit that, judging from Alice’s lifestyle as “Anomaly 099”, there was nothing wrong with hanging her head higher to let it air-dry.

The winch on the ship even treated taking naps as a habit, and the bucket used to scrub the deck rolled to the stern every afternoon to bask in the Sun. Life on this ship demanded a broad mind.

From that angle, this doll Alice, who had adapted to life on the ship, really had become one with the vessel…

“I’m glad you’re not angry, Captain!” Alice immediately smiled. She seemed to have not only adapted to life on this ship, but also gotten used to, or rather understood, the captain’s temper. She still felt awe toward this powerful ghost captain, but she was no longer just simply afraid as she had been at first. Now she was much more relaxed, even daring to bargain with him: “Then later, can I still hang my head…”

“No. Anywhere is fine except in front of the captain’s cabin door. Find yourself another spot.” Duncan shot the doll a look. “I don’t want to open my door and see a crew member’s head hanging there, or a headless body swaying around outside.”

Alice could only lower her head honestly: “Oh, okay.”

Duncan still watched her, looking thoughtful.

“Captain?” Alice felt a little creeped out under his gaze. “Why are you staring at me like that…”

“I just suddenly thought of something,” Duncan said as he pondered. “You shed hair, right? Do you lose hair when you wash it too? Then… will you go bald?”

Alice froze on the spot. Her expression looked just like pigeon AI when it glitched and locked up.

After a long moment, her eyes suddenly widened. She stared at Duncan in shock: “I… I… I never even thought about that! Captain, you…”

Her voice was almost breaking into a sob at the end, but she still didn’t dare say the last few words. What she actually wanted to ask was, “Captain, are you a devil?” but she was afraid Mr. Goathead would scold her for that, for underestimating the captain’s power and making the greatest calamity on the sea sound too kind…

Duncan didn’t care about whatever words Alice swallowed back. His thoughts had already wandered far: “Look, you can walk and jump and talk, but your body is still like a real doll’s. You don’t need to eat or drink, and even if a joint falls off, you can just shove it back in. So can I understand it this way: your hair is a nonrenewable resource. If you wash it too much, you’ll go bald… and if you comb it too much, you’ll go bald too?”

Alice was about to cry: “Captain, why would you think of something so scary…”

Duncan: “Actually, I’ve wanted to ask ever since you cooked that fish head soup.”

Sad as she was, Alice still blinked at that: “But I only cooked fish soup…”

Duncan replied with perfect confidence: “Nonsense. There was fish, there were heads, and there was soup. How is that not fish head soup?”

Alice: “…Captain, you’re reasonable.”

The beautiful morning on the Vanished began with everyone agreeing that the other was reasonable.

Miss Doll left in a daze, as if she suddenly had some major life issue about her future to think over. Duncan, meanwhile, felt in a good mood. He took in a breath of sea breeze, then ate a simple breakfast. It was made up of fish fillets Alice had grilled yesterday, chopped cheese, and strong liquor from the city-state of Pland. It was not very delicious, but it was currently the top-tier meal on the Vanished.

Inside the enchanted sea chart room in the captain's cabin, Goathead watched the cheerful Duncan curiously: "Captain, what happened to Miss Alice? I noticed she returned to the cabin absentmindedly and bumped into her door twice when she went back to her room… She seems very preoccupied?"

"She's facing a major life challenge. I think for quite a long time you won't have to worry about her fighting with the strange things on the ship," Duncan said, swirling the liquor in his glass with a mischievous grin. "But I really am curious about one thing…"

"Ah? Curious about what?"

"If a cursed Doll's hair all falls out, will she really turn into a bald doll?" Duncan began to discuss very seriously with Goathead. "For an supernatural thing like that, shouldn't there be some kind of supernatural power to guarantee… hmm, to guarantee a certain state? It's a pity I didn't have time to discuss it with Alice before she ran off."

Goathead: "…"

Duncan gave this usually noisy fellow a curious look: "Why aren't you saying anything?"

Goathead held it in for a long time before finally squeezing out a line: “You truly deserve to be the most terrifying calamity on the Boundless Sea… Even if you killed me, I could never think of a question like that.”

Duncan shrugged and stood up from behind the chart table.

“I’m going to head out again,” he said to Goathead. At the same time he snapped his fingers, and a cluster of emerald flame burst out of thin air. The undead bird-form pigeon AI descended from the fire and landed on his shoulder. “Same as usual, you’re in charge of the helm.”

“As you command, Captain. Your loyal, et cetera, will not let you down!” Goathead answered in an immediately rising tone, then asked curiously, “Captain, you seem… very keen on Spirit Realm walking lately. Is there something on land that has caught your interest?”

Duncan didn’t answer right away. He thought for a moment before speaking: “I suddenly realized recently that after a century of development, this world has become a little more interesting.”

He gave this answer after weighing it carefully. The sentence did not reveal any specific information, nor did it expose his lack of knowledge. At the same time, it planted a reasonable seed that would make it seem more normal when he later started paying frequent attention to the world on land. If necessary, it could also serve as a reasonable motive for the Vanished to return to the civilized world.

Besides, this answer should not clash too much with the image of “Captain Duncan”.

The greatest calamity on the Boundless Sea could also be someone who just wanted entertainment – and someone who wanted entertainment could accept anything.

As expected, Goathead showed no strange reaction at all, as if every decision Captain Duncan made was only natural: “Oh, you’re right. After so many years, those frail city-states should have come up with something to interest you. It’s normal if you want to use them to pass the time… In that case, should the Vanished make some preparations? Which one are you planning to invade? Pland? Lunsa? Or the more northern Frostholm?”

Duncan silently nodded along at the first half of Goathead’s words, thinking that this top lackey really did know how to read his master’s mood and play along. But when he heard the second half, his blood almost ran cold. The guy had gone from cooperating to egging him on. He had to cut him off at once: “When did I ever say I was going to invade any city-state? Something interesting has just appeared. Wouldn’t it be a shame to destroy it?”

“Ah… yes, you’re right. My suggestion was too rash,” Goathead quickly changed his tune. “I thought you planned to sail over for a spin in the future… Of course, since you have no such idea, that suggestion should be thrown out. Actually, that’s good too. After all, the big city-states still have some strength. Rushing too close would be a bit risky…”

“Don’t casually bring up invading city-states in the future.” Duncan gave Goathead a look and then added another layer of warning just in case. “We’ve been off track from the world for a hundred years. Now I need to get a new grasp of how civilized society has changed. That may involve many long-term changes. Before I give a clear order, don’t make any extra plans.”

“I will strictly follow your orders, Captain.”

Chapter 67: New Connections

Goathead was a dangerous fellow. Duncan had known that from the start. Its danger was not only that it was an Anomaly with unclear origins, but also that it had once sworn loyalty to the real Captain Duncan and even now still acted and thought according to the old rules.

In Goathead's eyes, the city-states on land were meaningless, the mortals in the city-states were ignorant and laughable, the weak city-state fleets were all food, and plundering and hunting them down was the Vanished's natural "daily routine".

Duncan did not know how long it would take to adjust Goathead's way of thinking, but he knew the process had to be subtle. Using reasonable excuses to change his own behavior and the Vanished's style of action was the safest way.

He cast one last glance at Goathead, who was quietly on standby on the chart table, and confirmed that it had already taken over the Vanished's sails and steering system. Only then did he push open the door and walk into his cabin.

This afternoon, Nina would return to the antique shop, and before that, he needed pigeon AI to complete more test tasks.

The door leading to the captain's room closed. In the dim light, Goathead quietly fixed its gaze on the door for a long, silent time. Only after it was sure the captain's consciousness had set out on a Spirit Realm walk did it mutter to itself softly: "Truly not affected by Subspace…"

In the gloom, the wooden Goathead creaked as it turned. It seemed to be looking around the room, yet also as if its gaze passed through the walls and swept over the whole ship.

“Oh, Vanished, Vanished… just what terrifying thing did you dredge up back then…”

…

Duncan had already returned to that familiar dark space. He felt his will stretch out among countless starlights and faint light lines. The two ends of its path were the Vanished and the antique shop in the city-state of Pland.

It seemed that as this “double connection” lasted longer, the feeling grew clearer as well. Now he did not even need to focus on purpose to sense what was happening on the antique shop’s side, and he could even remotely control the body in the shop to do some simple daily activities.

That was obviously a good thing. An antique shopkeeper who “slept” in the store more than half the time would clearly arouse suspicion. Even if that body just got up now and then to move around and stood at the door for a minute or two, it would dispel many unnecessary gazes.

Duncan did not immediately transfer his main consciousness to Pland. Instead, he stopped in the dark space, carefully feeling the changes within it, then turned to look beside him.

In the vast darkness, AI, in her bone-pigeon form, was circling silently. Her ghostly body scattered flecks of green fire as she flew. At the center of the area where AI circled were a few vague phantoms.

Among those phantoms were the Sun charm amulet he had brought aboard the Vanished earlier, an old, simple short dagger, a piece of cheese, a round cannonball, and a stiff dried salted fish.

These were all “test items” he had prepared before setting out, meant to further test AI’s ability to carry objects and any changes during the process.

The short dagger had been found in the cabins and might once have belonged to a sailor. It was a mindless “ordinary item”. The cheese was taken from the kitchen and had the property of not spoiling. The cannonball came from the magazine. The dried fish was one of the catches from the last fishing trip, just dried in the last two days. It was not fully dried yet, but already hard as a board.

Duncan watched AI circling around those phantoms and nodded slightly: “So this is how you carry objects every time.”

AI flapped her wings and gave a hoarse, sharp cry: “Hold on tight, hold on tight!”

Duncan chuckled, then focused his mind, ready to project his main consciousness.

But the instant he gathered his attention, he suddenly saw a strange glimmer appear at the end of the stream of light pointing toward Pland.

Duncan stopped at once and stared in surprise at that light which was now shining among the countless dim stars. It seemed the glow had already been there all along, but only turned from dark to bright in the instant he focused, as if being noticed had made it start to give off a clear sense of presence.

What was that?

Puzzled, Duncan tried to move toward that glimmer. With just a thought, he crossed the vast darkness. The glimmer swelled quickly before his eyes and turned into a flowing stream of light.

Only then did he see that between himself and that flowing light there was a faint line of connection, just like the link between his real body on the Vanished and the spare body in the antique shop.

Was this… another spare vessel waiting to be chosen?

Such a thought surfaced in Duncan's mind, but he soon shook his head. The flowing light in front of him was on a much larger scale than the light points that represented bodies. With such a broad glow, it was more likely not a vessel, but some huge object that had formed a connection with him.

Hesitating, he finally made up his mind and reached out to carefully touch that light…

The next second, a vast and unfamiliar sensation surged into his mind. He could not see the things around him, but he felt sea wind brushing over his body and waves gently rising and falling around him. He felt many people moving around him, even walking on his body. He heard voices talking from all directions, but all the sounds were mixed together and seemed to come through thick curtains, completely unclear.

He vaguely realized that he was sensing the environment through the perspective of some huge object. But this giant was not suitable for his spirit to descend into directly, or perhaps some power was protecting it and blocking his power from fully entering. Because of that, all his senses felt delayed and muffled.

This giant seemed to be resting on the sea near the shore, with many people gathered there.

A tense and serious atmosphere filled the crowd. They seemed to be solemnly dealing with some dangerous factor, and everyone's conversations were low and brief.

Duncan tried hard to focus, wanting to hear what exactly those voices, muffled as if through thick curtains, were talking about.

He worked at it for a long time before he finally picked out a single word that kept being repeated from the overlapping buzzing voices – the White

Oak.

Duncan drew back the hand touching the light stream and stared, a bit stunned, at the floating glow before him.

The glow drifted in the darkness, faintly forming the outline of a ship.

The White Oak… The name sounded somewhat familiar, but he could not remember when he had heard it.

Duncan thought hard, digging through his memories until some rough impressions surfaced. He recalled the ship he had crashed into while he was steering for the first time in the Spirit Realm. He remembered that when the Vanished passed straight through it, he seemed to have seen its name on one side of the hull… That ship seemed to be called the White Oak.

Right after that, he remembered the newspaper he had bought in Pland. In an inconspicuous section, it had mentioned this as well, saying that the long-distance ship White Oak, missing for several days, would be docking soon…

Duncan stared blankly at the floating glow before him.

This was the White Oak, the White Oak that had been responsible for escorting Anomaly 099.

It seemed that the old captain who had tried to shout at him and his crew members had finally reached Pland safely. That was actually quite pleasing.

Clearly, he had formed a connection with this ship.

Had the connection been formed after that Spirit Realm collision back then? Because the flames of the Vanished had spread onto the White Oak at the time?

A faint guess rose in Duncan’s heart, and he used it to speculate about all the properties of his spirit form flames. At the same time, he thought about

whether his link with this steamship could be put to use.

After drifting on the Vanished for so long, he treasured every single thread of connection between himself and the civilized world.

Now it seemed that although the White Oak had docked, it was still under some kind of lockdown and surveillance. Those tense people were probably professionals from the city-state who specialized in dealing with supernatural Visions.

Clearly, for the people in the city-state, a ship that had been lost at sea carried a dangerous risk, and its experience of having had zero-distance contact with the Vanished was probably another major issue waiting for review.

Duncan was quite aware of his own fearsome reputation and that of the Vanished.

After thinking it over, Duncan cautiously backed away and did not touch the cloud of light again.

As the number one boss on the Boundless Sea, he had no intention of dealing with the Guardians of the City-State. And while he still did not know what those Occult Specialists were like, he also did not want to expose the fact that the White Oak had already formed a connection with “Captain Duncan”.

He definitely did not want anyone to discover and sever his link with this steamship. The connection was already in place, as firm as an anchor chain beneath the waves. He could be patient. One day, the surveillance on the White Oak would be lifted.

By then, he might even be able to have a calm chat with that old captain.

He could ask what exactly the old captain had been shouting at him back then when the wind and waves were so strong.

Chapter 68: Reliable Pigeon Courier

A cool sea breeze suddenly swept across the deck, making Captain Lawrence-M, who had just stepped out from inside, rub his arms without thinking. He did not even know whether this urge to get goosebumps came from the cool wind, or from what that young Inquisitor had just told him.

Anomaly 099, the Doll spirit coffin, after entering a runaway state, not only gained the ability to move and a strong tendency to escape its container, but also kept expanding its range of influence. Inside that range it would constantly check for humanoid targets and carry out unconditional Decapitation. Only the Saint might be able to resist this almost causal Decapitation effect…

During the past half-month of sailing, he and his crew members had been living side by side with this dangerous Anomaly. Although in fact, aside from running into the Vanished at the end, nothing truly dangerous had happened during this escort voyage, when Lawrence-M thought back on it now, he still felt a little shaken.

But it was only a lingering fear, nothing more.

He was a member of the Explorer Association, a veteran ocean explorer. His job was to deal with the Boundless Sea. Unlike those fishermen who only worked in the safe nearshore waters, more than half of his seafaring life had been spent dealing with all kinds of Anomalies and even Visions.

Whenever he accepted a transport job involving an Anomaly, the authority or the Church would warn him in advance about the danger of the trip. That part of the commission contract was always the shortest section, usually only one line: this task is deadly; specific details cannot be disclosed.

Every captain who made a living sailing between city-states knew what they were facing. More than half of them spent their later years haunted by this deadly career. After many years dealing with the Boundless Sea, Anomalies and Visions always left something on your fate.

Many colleagues of his age had already retired. Some were trapped in endless nightmares. Some had mental problems from different degrees of the curse. Some came back from long voyages with maimed limbs… or ended even worse.

Captains and sailors on deep-sea ships earned pay far beyond what any city-state resident could imagine, and they also carried “occupational diseases” far worse than in any other profession.

Captain Lawrence-M felt he was not a very noble person. He did this job mainly to earn money. Of course, when he was young, he had a strong passion to explore the sea. But like most people, the passion of youth was hard to carry through a whole life. And now… he felt that last bit of passion was almost burned out.

While his mind was still sound, while the Boundless Sea had not fully tangled itself around his fate, he should find a time to retire.

Lawrence-M let out a small sigh, turned around, and slowly walked toward the captain’s cabin.

The priests’ search and questioning of the whole ship had not finished yet. Before that, he still could not leave the White Oak. After that, he and

everyone else would be transferred to the Cathedral for Quarantine Observation and a series of mental evaluations.

His gaze swept over the familiar fittings around the ship.

It was a very good ship, and very new. He had commanded her for only five years. As the captains on the Boundless Sea liked to say, “the honeymoon between captain and ship isn’t even over yet.” To be honest, he felt quite reluctant to retire from her.

But retiring now was still better than dying in some future voyage, or spending the rest of his life in an asylum.

…

In the Lower City of the city-state, inside Duncan’s old, shabby antique shop, the middle-aged man lying in the bed on the second floor slowly opened his eyes. The slightly old and moldy ceiling reflected into Duncan’s vision.

“Whew…”

Duncan let out a light breath. The senses from this body quickly became clear and steady. He felt his way of controlling this body shift from remote manipulation to direct command. After two or three seconds, he braced himself with his arms and pushed his body up.

The pigeon AI fluttered over, rubbed its beak on the headboard by his pillow, and noisily squawked: “Darling, welcome home. Do you want to eat first, or bathe first, or…”

Duncan had just been about to stretch when that one line from the pigeon almost made him cramp. He slapped a hand down on AI’s head at once: “Why do you know all that kind of phrasing?!”

AI was clearly no ordinary bird. After being smacked by Duncan, it acted as if nothing had happened. It cheerfully paced a few steps to the side, still chattering: “With one punch, it landed right on his nose, blood spraying everywhere, his nose knocked to one side, as if he’d opened a sauce shop…”

Duncan simply set this not-quite-right-in-the-head bird aside and stopped paying attention to it. He got out of bed and looked toward the nearby table.

On the table quietly lay all the test items he had prepared earlier on the Vanished:

The Sun Charm amulet, a dagger, a piece of cheese, a cannonball, and a salted fish.

Everything was there. With so many random and unrelated things piled together, AI had not “lost a package.”

This pigeon was actually more reliable than Duncan had expected.

Duncan walked over and checked each item on the table. After making sure every item was present and undamaged, he could not help glancing back at the pigeon pacing on the bed. A bit of praise rose in his heart for the bird.

Then he saw AI pacing in a neat square at the head of the bed. It had already gotten to the line: “When Luda looked, he saw Zento lying straight on the ground”…

Duncan: “…”

He hid his praise deep in his heart, then sat down at the table and began checking the “goods” one by one.

First was the Sun Charm amulet. It had not changed at all. As an supernatural item that had already been fully reworked and controlled by the fire of his spirit form, the gentle power inside it still flowed quietly. Two

consecutive trips walking through the Spirit Realm did not seem to affect the nature of this item.

The dagger, which did not have any supernatural properties, also did not look changed. Aside from its old-fashioned style, its blade was still sharp, and the sheath was still well maintained.

Duncan's eyes fell on the piece of cheese he had taken from the Vanished's galley.

The cheese showed no sign of being an Anomaly. It was still in that unfit-for-eating state. It did not rot quickly or vanish in thin air after leaving the Vanished, as Duncan had imagined.

He then looked at the cannonball.

The cannonball sat quietly on the table and showed no reaction to the captain's gaze.

Duncan nudged the cannonball and knocked on its cast-iron shell.

Its supernatural traits had faded away.

On the Vanished, even the cannonballs were "active." Of course, that did not mean each cannonball had its own independent "mind." It meant the ship's entire ammunition system was controlled by a unified "consciousness." As a sub-unit of that consciousness, every cannonball on the Vanished would immediately adjust its position and line up for "inspection" whenever the captain used his gaze on them.

From Duncan's observations over some time, there were probably two "consciousnesses" controlling the combat systems of the Vanished. One belonged to the ammunition system, and one belonged to the dozens of cannons under the deck. These two consciousnesses seemed to be in charge of loading and firing during battle, each controlling every "member" inside its own system.

The cannonball in front of him had clearly fallen out of that higher consciousness's control after leaving the Vanished and had become a plain, ordinary lump of iron.

Duncan became thoughtful.

If he brought this cannonball back to the Vanished, would it rejoin the ammunition storage? Would the Vanished still "recognize" this sub-unit that had gone away and returned?

His thoughts stretched out further. The ammunition on the Vanished was limited. The cannonballs it fired would not come back. (The eight cannonballs he had used earlier to weigh down Alice's coffin had not come back either.) So… could the ship's ammunition be resupplied? And how did new ammunition added to the ship become sub-units of the Vanished?

His thinking expanded another step: could the Vanished upgrade its artillery system? Could more advanced cannons and more advanced shells work if they were mounted on that ship?

The Vanished was a ghost ship. That meant it was hard for it to resupply or "upgrade" as easily as an ordinary vessel. Anything carried aboard was just an "external item." If it could not smoothly become a part of the Vanished, then these external items could not gain the convenient "self-operating" traits that the rest of the ship's systems had.

But if there was a way to turn those things into parts of the Vanished itself… that ghost ship might wield an even greater power.

And at the same time have far better living conditions.

Duncan could not help thinking a lot along these lines.

The more he came into contact with modern Pland, the more he felt that the Vanished from a century ago was not as glorious and perfect as its fearsome reputation.

That ship might have eerie and terrifying power, but it did not even have electric lights, and it certainly did not have fries. Its weapon system still used old muzzle-loading cannons. Who knew how strong they really were? And again, there were no fries.

The sails of spirit form were useful, but having a steam engine as backup power would clearly be nice too. Yet the ship did not even have a boiler to heat water.

And still no fries.

Duncan silently glanced at the pigeon that had hopped up onto the windowsill and was staring blankly outside.

The pigeon turned its head back and blinked its tiny green-bean eyes at him: “Want to go down to the docks and get some fries?”

“Shut up. Don’t mention fries.” Duncan turned the bird down with mixed feelings, then finally shifted his attention to the last item.

The salted fish was a pure natural food, processed from a delicious gift hooked out of the Deep Sea. It tasted pretty good and was one of the few things that counted as “from outside the Vanished.”

After walking through the Spirit Realm, this salted fish also did not look any different.

[Let’s use it to make soup for Nina tonight.]

Chapter 69: City-State Life

After checking all the test items, Duncan had a clearer understanding of AI's transport ability and of the nature of the things on the Vanished.

AI could carry several different items at once. Those items could be organic, inorganic, supernatural, or ordinary. The type of item did not affect the stability of the transport process, and the transport did not change the nature of the items themselves.

Some things on the Vanished that clearly had "the ability to act" were actually sub-units under a larger controlling consciousness. For example, the cannonballs were sub-units of the ammunition system. Once these sub-units left the Vanished, they lost their active nature and became plain, ordinary objects.

AI's transport process did not seem to cost it much "energy." Whether it carried only the ritual dagger the first time or a whole pile of items now, the bird still came back lively and bouncing around. Of course, this might be because the total "cargo" he had asked it to carry so far was still too small and far from its limit.

For now he had only tested different kinds of items. He still did not know whether AI's transport ability had limits on "weight" or "size." That needed further testing.

Duncan summed up the known information point by point. After making sure he had thought through everything, he finally let out a breath and slowly leaned back in his chair.

He knew his current tests were still far from perfect. There were many possible variables he had not considered carefully enough. Even just from the angle of “types of test items,” his samples were too few. They were not enough to build up valid data.

In the future, he would at least need to choose more types of items. He would also have to use different weights and sizes to test AI’s transport limits and the stability of repeated transports. Only with enough control samples would his test data be reliable and trustworthy.

He was very careful in this area, and that caution was not for nothing—because he had a very bold plan… or rather, a very bold idea.

Since AI could teleport items between land and the Vanished intact, and without being limited by the type of item, then… could it deliver a person?

If it could deliver a person, could it deliver someone who did not quite count as a person? For example… Alice?

Duncan knew a single person’s ability was limited. If he relied only on his own power to walk through the Spirit Realm and act as a link between the Vanished and the city-states on land, sooner or later he would run into problems—too few hands, too many things to watch. If he had a helper, things would be much easier.

The teleportation ability AI showed gave him a very good idea.

Of course, Alice was not a very good choice for a helper. This “Anomaly 099” with a high-rank designation might look elegant and mysterious when she sat quietly, but as soon as she moved, she revealed just how weak and useless she was. For now, though, Duncan really had no other candidate.

Thinking that his only usable crew member was such a helpless good-for-nothing who might even stew herself while cooking, Duncan could not help sighing.

The “enemy of the whole world” status of the Vanished really gave him a headache. Duncan guessed that he had almost no chance of finding allies in the human world. If he insisted on looking, he would probably only draw in a group of edgy villains—the kind of people who opened their eyes every morning hoping for the world’s doomsday, who spent Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays cutting gas pipes, Tuesdays, Thursdays, and Saturdays holding demon sacrificial rites, and Sundays fighting guerrilla battles with Church guardians…

Those types could probably team up with Goathead very quickly. They would have a great time together planning which city-state to invade next, but they were absolutely not the kind of help Duncan wanted.

“…Sigh, at least Alice is obedient,” Duncan muttered to himself as he stood up, talking under his breath. “If I train her carefully, she might grow into something… maybe.”

Even if she could not become a helper, it would still be good to let that Doll see the human world. After all, she had been locked in a coffin for so many years. She had no idea what the outside world looked like.

After sorting out his thoughts, Duncan began putting away the pile of things he had brought over. He would not return to the Vanished for now. Many of these things could not be carried with him, so of course he had to leave them in the shop.

There were not many hiding places on the second floor of the antique shop. Nina might come upstairs at any time to help tidy the room. Some things that clearly did not look like daily necessities would be especially suspicious if left in the bedroom—for example, a cannonball from a century ago. But after a short think, Duncan found reasonable homes for them all.

The Sun Charm amulet could simply be kept close to his body. The salted fish could go straight into the kitchen, which looked perfectly natural. As

for the century-old cannonball and the century-old sailor’s dagger, those were even simpler—

Duncan brought those two things down to the shop on the first floor and set them in an inconspicuous corner beside the counter. After all, this was an antique shop. There were as many odd-looking things here as anyone could want. Nowhere could hide a dagger and a cannonball better than the pile of shabby fake junk on the first floor…

As for the last item, the piece of cheese from the Vanished’s galley, Duncan also found a very suitable place for it.

The trash bin.

After finishing all this, Duncan patted the nonexistent dust off his hands and felt very satisfied with his arrangements.

Then he glanced at the sky outside.

The Sun, sealed and bound by two rings of runes, hung high in the sky. It was just noon.

Nina would return home later today. Before that, he planned to go out and walk around a bit, to learn more about this city.

Anyway, it did not look like the antique shop would get any business today.

The weather was a bit cool. Duncan put on a dark brown coat, and before going out he tidied his somewhat messy, decadent hair, trying his best to make this body—once tormented by alcohol, drugs, and sickness—look a little more spirited. Then he left the antique shop.

As soon as he stepped out the door, he heard wings flapping from the second floor. The pigeon AI flew out of the room on its own and landed on his shoulder. It rocked its head and, full of pride, chattered: “Go to Twin Immortals Bridge, take Chenghua Avenue…”

Duncan gave the bird a sideways look at once. He had originally planned to leave the pigeon on the second floor to watch the house. After all, having a pigeon on your shoulder when you went out drew way too much attention and felt strange. Besides, Duncan and AI were linked by spirit flame. If anything happened, he could always summon it with his spirit form fire at any time. There was no risk of delay.

He just had not given the order before leaving, so the bird had “gotten on board” by itself.

Looking at the smug expression of this crafty bird, Duncan finally sighed with a helpless smile: “…Fine. Follow me if you want.”

With the pigeon still on his shoulder, he walked to the main road across from the antique shop. After following the main road for only a short distance, he heard the clear chime of a bell mixed with the sound of a steam engine drawing near. He looked up and saw a brown double-decker bus with blue stripes along its sides driving down the main road and slowly stopping at a nearby stop.

It was a very common public transport in the city-state of Pland, driven by a steam engine. The fare was six peso and it could reach most parts of the Lower City. According to the route map on the back of the bus, the line’s last two stops also passed along the edge of the Upper City, at a place called Crossroad District.

Duncan had an impression of “Crossroad District” in his mind. He knew that street and the area around it were seen as the “border zone” of Pland. It had fairly busy businesses and fairly respectable housing. Many residents of the Lower City took Crossroad District as the goal and dream of “moving up a level in life.” Many mid-level citizens who could not afford the high costs of the Upper City but still wanted a decent life also lived there. There

were also cinemas, the City Museum, and several higher-end restaurants in that area.

Nina’s school was near Crossroad District, and the City Museum she had mentioned was also next to it.

Duncan thought for a moment, then quickly walked to the stop and boarded the bus before it started moving.

There were not many people on the bus. More than half of the seats on the lower deck were empty. Beside the driver’s seat stood a young conductress in a dark blue uniform. She had shoulder-length hair and light makeup. When she saw someone get on, her hand went to her ticket pouch out of habit, but then she noticed the pigeon on Duncan’s shoulder.

“Sorry, you can’t bring pets on the bus, that’s the rule,” the young woman said, raising her hand to point at the pigeon on Duncan’s shoulder. “That includes pigeons.”

Duncan looked at AI. AI flapped its wings innocently and tilted its head at him.

“Go cling to the roof.”

“Coo, coo.”

AI flapped its wings and flew out of the bus, “coo-coo-coo” cursing all the way.

The young conductress-Miss stared blankly at the man who could talk with a pigeon, and at the pigeon that really seemed to understand human speech. For a long moment, she could not say anything.

“Is it okay now?” Duncan had to remind the conductress, who seemed a bit dazed. He pointed up toward the roof: “You can’t control a bird sitting on the roof, right?”

The conductress finally came back to herself: “Ah… yes… the fare is six peso, full ticket.”

Duncan reached into his pocket, took out two coins, and traded them for a blue ticket. Then he found a seat by the window, sat down quietly, and got ready to enjoy his first bus ride in this world.

The steam engine started. With a light vibration and the sound of machinery grinding, the bell at the front of the bus rang out clear and bright. The bus gave a gentle jolt, and the view outside the window began to slide backward.

Duncan leaned back comfortably in the seat and felt the tremors and acceleration as this piece of mechanical engineering moved.

Steam engines were a good thing. Civilized society was a good thing. Technological progress was a good thing.

If he had the chance, he definitely wanted to install a set on the Vanished too—even just a boiler that could heat water. Then people on the ship could take hot baths in the future.

Just as his thoughts were spreading out, Duncan felt the bus suddenly jolt. The scenery outside the window slowly stopped.

The young conductress-Miss pushed open the window near the front, leaned out, and shouted to the street: “Getting on? There are seats! All big seats!”

Duncan blinked, then let out a soundless laugh.

In that moment, he suddenly felt that this city-state, which was still unfamiliar to him, was filled with the breath of everyday life.

Chapter 70: One of Us

In a world where supernatural Visions existed, the land was sealed off by a boundless sea, and Guardians and Anomalies fought without end in the city-states, how did ordinary people survive?

Duncan still did not understand this city-state well, but at least in the places he had seen, the ordinary people of this world still lived in order and stability.

They worked, studied, and rested. They ran shops and traded goods. On their days off, they went out to cinemas and restaurants, to parks and the harbor. They visited the city museum and chatted with their neighbors after dinner. Their lives were not very exciting, but they were usually peaceful.

The steam-engine bus started and stopped, sometimes at a stop, sometimes by the roadside. Passengers got on and off at any moment. The silent driver only spoke a couple of words to the conductor now and then, but most of the time he focused on driving. The young conductor kept glancing up at the roof from time to time—she still seemed to be thinking about that pigeon.

Duncan sat in his seat, watching everything around him with curiosity, watching these lives that belonged to ordinary people.

It seemed that aside from needing to know that Anomalies and Visions existed in the world, and treating that knowledge as a kind of “safety code” to follow, the lives of these ordinary people were not much different from what he had seen on Earth.

When they neared Crossroad District, the bus stopped again. This time it stopped at a proper platform, and many passengers got on there.

Duncan looked curiously at the view from the platform. He watched the distant chimneys standing tall and the steam pipes crisscrossing above the roofs. Then, all of a sudden, he faintly felt an unusual heat rising near his chest.

The heat came from the Sun badge he had hidden close to his body.

Duncan, who had been enjoying the scenery, froze for a moment. He instinctively touched the place where the badge was hidden. The next second, he felt that the badge was not only hot, but also trembling slightly.

He did not know what was happening, but clearly the badge was resonating with something nearby. Through the link already formed between him and the badge, he clumsily searched for the source of that resonance. A moment later, his eyes locked onto a figure outside the bus window, hurrying through the crowd.

The figure wore a black coat and looked like an ordinary passerby, but the “directional sense” coming from the Sun badge clearly and unmistakably pointed at him.

Duncan stood up at once and strode toward the door. As his thoughts moved, the pigeon AI also received his command. She flapped her wings, flew down from the roof of the bus, and landed on his shoulder.

The conductor standing near the door stared in surprise at this scene. Only after Duncan stepped off the bus did she mutter under her breath: “How did he train that pigeon…”

But the little episode of daily life quickly slipped out of the young Miss conductor’s attention. She turned to the passengers who had just gotten on and said: “Come over here to buy your tickets… the child needs a ticket

too. No way that kid is under one meter ten… Four years old? There's no way that's four. Once you cross the line, it's a full ticket!"

By then, Duncan had already walked into the crowd. He moved quickly through the busy platform and the intersection, tracking the figure in the black coat.

The man in black walked very fast. The dense afternoon foot traffic along the street made it easy for him to slip out of sight. In just a few minutes, the figure had already vanished from Duncan's view.

However, the Sun badge kept resonating. The directional sense from deep inside it continued to point Duncan toward the right direction.

Duncan followed the badge's guidance as he kept tracking, thinking quickly at the same time.

There was no doubt the man in black was suspicious. The badge had to have sensed something for it to react so suddenly… perhaps it had sensed a power of the same origin, coming from the true Sun god.

From Goathead, he already knew that this badge could recognize its own kind and guide the Sun's divine blessing. Under normal circumstances, only believers of the Sun god could use those functions or feel the badge's guidance.

Duncan had used the fire of his spirit form to seize control of the badge. Back then, he had thought his flames had destroyed most of its abilities as well. But now it seemed… the badge's power of recognition was still there.

Only now, that recognition served him instead.

Guided by the badge, he gradually left the crowded main street. After twisting through several turns, he walked into quieter, emptier side lanes.

He saw the suspicious figure again. The man was hurrying across an intersection up ahead, still seeming completely unaware of the tracker behind him.

Vaguely, Duncan felt the badge on his chest grow even hotter than before. The resonance became clearer and stronger.

Duncan quietly stirred the fire of his spirit form and read the information coming from the Sun badge. A flood of clear, directional sensations poured into his mind at once.

The feeling was strange. Although the Sun badge had no will of its own, Duncan almost felt it was excitedly pushing messages at him. It was telling him, a man who did not believe in the Sun god, where all the other believers were.

He even wanted to remind the badge to calm down a bit. Not long ago it had still been the Sun god's sacred relic. Even if it was acting as a guide now, it did not need to get as excited as a pocket hand warmer.

At the same time, he became more and more sure that he was approaching a secret assembly hall where many believers of the Sun god gathered.

Just as he had expected, more "Sun heretics" had gathered in the dark corners of this city-state. The group that had been wiped out in the sewers before had only been one small part of these cockroach-like cultists.

He did not know what these cultists really wanted, but he knew they must understand ancient history, the Sun faith, and the Age of Order far better than Nina's teachers.

If he wanted to learn the secrets in the deep layers of this world, he had to contact forces from the supernatural field. It was very hard to get close to the Church and the city's authority by normal means. cultists were much easier—he just had to blend in with them.

Or beat them into one big pile. That worked too.

Duncan was thinking about this when he suddenly stopped.

He had reached the end of a narrow lane. The sneaky man in black had just slipped into a nearby alley, and the signal from the Sun badge was clear and strong. There was not a single passerby in sight.

Through the Sun badge, he sensed more “kin signals” gathering near where he stood.

Duncan quietly raised the collar of his coat, hiding half his face in it. Almost the moment he finished the motion, he heard many footsteps in the shadows of the nearby buildings.

One figure after another appeared.

There were more than ten people, dressed no differently from ordinary citizens. After all, no cultist would walk around the city at noon in a full robe, just like a proper assassin should not wear a glaring white hooded cloak while doing business on a busy street.

Only the constant heat and clear directional signals from the Sun badge let him be sure that every last one of these people appearing around him was a follower of the true Sun god.

Duncan raised his head and looked toward the end of the lane. The man in the black coat he had been tracking stood among them, watching him warily. Beside him, a tall, thin young man said a few quiet words to his companions before finally looking Duncan’s way.

The tall, thin man spoke: “This is private property. Why did you sneak in here after us?” He still seemed to be trying to give off the feeling that they were all ordinary citizens and that Duncan was the suspicious one. Since he did not know who this follower was, he neither attacked rashly nor relaxed his guard.

Duncan muttered inwardly that an amateur like him really was not suited for this kind of professional tracking work. At the same time, he was curious what these cultists planned to do with him if he played dumb. Would they pretend to be a group of dutiful local thugs and scare him off, or would they zealously grow their cult, tie him up, and offer him as a nice meaty sacrifice to their Sun god?

The tall, thin man frowned and spoke impatiently: “Didn’t you hear me? I’m asking you a question…” As he spoke, the figures around him all took half a step forward without drawing attention, forming a vague circle.

Duncan shrugged. He casually pulled the Sun charm amulet from his coat and said in a sincere tone: “I’m one of you.”

First, he would try to get on their good side. Maybe that would make them talk more.

If they still did not believe him, then he would beat them into one big pile.

Chapter 71: Gathering in the Gutters

The moment Duncan took out the Sun charm amulet, a few seconds of silence fell over the group. His plain words “I’m one of you” drifted through the air, and they led to more than a dozen surprised and cautious glances being traded back and forth. Then the tall, thin man who looked like a small leader suddenly lowered his voice and said quickly: “Put that away! Watch out for Church spies nearby!”

So the charm amulet really worked? Was this thing really so convincing among Suntists?

Duncan was amused, but on the surface he kept his blank, mysterious posture with half his face hidden by his collar. He put the charm amulet away and said calmly: “If there really are Church spies nearby, your big group gathering here is much more eye-catching than my charm amulet.”

As soon as he finished, a scruffy, unshaven man blurted out: “No way. Us gathering at most will bring the constables over and get us charged for disturbing public order…”

“Shut up!” The tall, thin leader stopped his underling’s nonsense at once. Then his gaze fell on Duncan. “This is necessary caution. After all, the city isn’t very safe right now. Walk over here, and don’t make any extra moves.”

Duncan walked toward them calmly. The other man looked him up and down carefully. After staring at him for a long time, the tall, thin man finally asked in a low voice: “Are you a believer who lives in this city?”

Duncan thought for a moment and nodded: “Yes.”

The original master of this body had indeed lived in the city, and Duncan lived here now as well. On questions this obvious, he decided to tell the truth.

His plan was simple. He would find a way to blend into this group of cultists, then see what information he could pick up. If he did not get exposed, he would listen and ask more. If he did get exposed, he would have AI transform and deal with all of them.

The tall, thin man had no idea what dangerous thoughts this “Church brother” in front of him was turning over in his mind. He went on and asked: “As far as I know, the Deep Sea Church attacked a few days ago…”

“The assembly hall in the sewers,” Duncan said without the slightest burden, cutting in smoothly. “A Sun rite was going on there at the time. The ritual went out of control, and we lost many people—but I escaped.” While he spoke, he watched the reactions of the Suntists around him. He could feel the tension in their bodies clearly loosen. Only the tall, thin little leader in front of him still stayed cautious. “Three others escaped with me, but we got separated. Now I’ve completely lost contact with the Church—until I met you. The Sun gave me guidance.”

The tall, thin man only grunted, neither agreeing nor denying it. Then his gaze fell on Duncan’s shoulder: “What is that?”

“My pet,” Duncan said casually. “Can’t you tell? Just an ordinary pigeon.”

AI shook her head at just the right time and let out a loud “coo.”

“This pigeon is loud…” The tall, thin man finally seemed to relax. Deep down, he probably also felt that those rule-bound Church people would never have the habit of running all over the city with a bird on their shoulder. He nodded and said: “Come with me. It’s not safe to talk outside.”

Duncan let out a breath in his heart. It seemed that the first step of his plan to fish in troubled waters had worked.

Then he followed the group of cultists as they walked deeper into the alley.

The alley was deeper than he had thought. It seemed to lead into the most forgotten, darkest core of this rundown district. The group of cultists led Duncan through turn after turn, past old pipes that constantly vented steam, across narrow lanes where sewage flowed, and finally into a cluster of low, shabby buildings. The deeper they went, the more the dark and broken side of this prosperous steam metropolis revealed itself before Duncan.

He had thought that the place where he and Nina lived was already part of the city's lowest neighborhoods. Now he suddenly realized that their shabby antique shop was actually one of the more "respectable" spots in the Lower City.

Most of the rundown houses along the road looked lifeless, as if they had been abandoned for a long time. But in the shadows of a few houses, Duncan seemed to feel a numb or gloomy divine gaze, as if homeless people hid in this forgotten district and watched the intruders coldly.

In the end, those chilling gazes quickly pulled back. The dozen or so people led by the tall, thin man were clearly enough to make the squatters here feel afraid.

"See this? This is the most prosperous city-state on the Boundless Sea, Pland," the man in black who had first caught Duncan's attention muttered. It sounded like he was talking to himself, yet also as if he was speaking to Duncan. "It's the same everywhere. Lunsa is like this, Cold Harbor is like this. Even that place the elves call the 'land of peace and justice,' Lightwind Harbor, is like this… They claim that so-called 'Sun' shines fairly on the world and brings light and order to all things, but how much sunlight ever reaches these gutters?"

Duncan did not answer. He only looked up.

Above the low, shabby buildings, steam and fuel pipes from the Upper City and the industrial districts crisscrossed the sky. Huge valves and pressure assemblies sprawled like strange beasts over the rooftops. sunlight leaked through gaps between the pipes and fell on the sewage between the buildings, bringing out an even stronger stench.

Most of that sewage came from leaking pipes nearby, formed from condensed steam. As the city ran day after day, chemicals from the factories mixed into it, and it piled up in the Lower City.

Duncan did not need to live in the city long. One look was enough for him to guess how this kind of “urban abscess” had formed.

He quietly glanced at the angry man in black. His expression stayed calm.

Whether they were bewitched by the Sun’s spawn or driven by their harsh lives, these cultists did have their reasons for becoming what they were. But so what?

These cultists, who believed the city-state had forced them to live in the gutters, still came down to the Lower City to grab helpless poor people as living sacrifices. The countless ragged people in that cave had not included a single respectable person from the Upper City.

As a “foreigner” who still did not understand this world well, Duncan felt he had no need to judge this city-state too much. But at least as a former sacrificial victim, he felt these cultists really were scum.

In silence, he finally reached the cultists’ base.

The base was under an abandoned factory.

These cultists who crawled through gutters always seemed able to find a suitable one and turn it into their gathering spot. Or maybe this prosperous

steam metropolis simply had countless gutters, perfect for breeding dark and blasphemous things.

They climbed over the half-collapsed factory yard wall and opened an iron door leading down into the underground structures. Duncan had wanted to take a good look at the factory itself to satisfy his curiosity about this “age of steam,” but he never got the chance. They led him straight down a slanted stairway and into the cultists’ “secret base.”

This place might once have been the factory’s warehouse, or maybe a machinery room, but it had clearly been emptied out. In the large space, only the remaining pipe system on the ceiling and dead gas lamps on the walls remained. Darkness was dangerous, and even cultists knew that, so they had lit oil lamps fueled by whale oil all over the underground. In the light of many oil lamps, Duncan saw more than a dozen cultists gathered here.

After the Church had destroyed one sacrificial site so badly, there were still so many Sun believers gathered here? Where had all these cultists come from? Were they like mushrooms and moss, springing up on their own wherever there was a gutter?

Duncan stared in surprise at the figures gathered in the wide basement, and the cultists watched him with the same mix of curiosity and wariness. The tall, thin man walked over again, with several strong, burly cultists following close behind to stand around Duncan.

Duncan frowned and said: “What, you still have to search me again after I come in? I didn’t know there was such a rule.”

“If you really were a Church spy, a body search wouldn’t help,” the tall, thin man said. He took a strip of cloth from his coat and handed it to Duncan. “Relax. This is just a stricter test, only necessary caution. We’ve

lost many comrades over the years for all kinds of reasons. Hold this, then repeat after me."

Duncan glanced at what he was given. It was a filthy strip of cloth, as if torn from some old garment. Dark brown stains marked its surface, like dried blood.

Was this another tool Sun believers used to test their own?

Duncan was a little surprised. He could not help thinking that these people really were professionals who spent all day being hunted. He had not seen much of their fighting ability yet, but their skills at guarding against spies from outside and traitors inside seemed maxed out.

He took the strip from the man and heard the tall, thin man mutter a few lines in a low voice: "In the name of the Sun, may the Lord's radiance shine everywhere…"

As soon as Duncan heard it, he felt it was extremely familiar—just not long ago, a cultist had recited this to him.

That cultist had even given him an amulet.

Without changing his expression, Duncan lifted a finger slightly. A tiny green flame no one could see seeped into the ordinary-looking strip of cloth in his hand. Then he kept a straight face and copied the tall, thin man in front of him, repeating the lines of prayer.

The strip of cloth that seemed soaked with old blood stayed quietly in his hand, showing no sign of reaction.

The tall, thin man's gaze stayed on the strip for a long moment. At last he nodded lightly, took the cloth back from Duncan, and said with a smile: "Welcome back into the Lord's glory, brother."

Chapter 72: News from the Assembly Ground

To be fair, these cultists were actually quite cautious.

They did not trust this strange “comrade” just because Duncan took out the Sun Charm amulet. They also did not believe his story just because Duncan could describe what had happened in the sacrificial site in the sewers. All the way here, they watched his every move and every word. Even after they reached the assembly ground, they still carried out an extra test to confirm this stranger’s identity. For a group of cultists who lived in hiding, this was already the best they could do.

But all their screening methods treated Duncan as an ordinary human.

Those methods meant nothing to the captain of the Vanished.

The tall, skinny leader took the inconspicuous strip of cloth back from Duncan’s hand. He seemed completely unaware of how the power inside this extraordinary item had changed. After welcoming the new comrade, he raised his hand and pointed to a corner of the assembly ground and said: “Comrade, rest here for now. You are not the only unfamiliar face in this place.”

Duncan nodded and walked toward that unremarkable corner. At the same time, he watched every face that appeared in the assembly ground.

Unlike what he had seen earlier in the sacrificial site in the sewers, he was surprised to find that these Suntists were not wearing those distinctive black

robes. They were dressed like ordinary citizens. They did not hide their faces under hoods either, but calmly showed their faces.

Duncan asked the believer beside him, curious: “When you gather here, do you not need to hide your faces?”

The believer he asked looked very surprised: “…The local believers here in the city-state of Pland all had to hide their faces during gatherings before?”

Duncan frowned slightly at once: “You are not from Pland…”

“We came from Lunsa,” another believer nearby said calmly. After confirming that the stranger in front of them really was a comrade of the Church, the Suntists here had clearly relaxed their guard. “We only settled down last week, but before we could even make contact with the local brothers and sisters, that attack happened…”

“Everyone here came from Lunsa?” Duncan was a little surprised. He finally understood why there were still so many Sun believers in the city even after the sacrificial site in the sewers had been destroyed.

“Yes. The comrades gathered here all came from Lunsa, though there are also groups from other city-states. Everyone is scattered in different safe houses,” another believer joined the conversation. “Sigh, we have all heard more or less about the situation in Pland. In the past four years, that damned Governor and the Church’s hyenas kept cracking down on our work… You have not had it easy either, but at least that is over now.”

Duncan only nodded without agreeing or denying. Then he heard the cultist he had questioned at the start speak again: “That pigeon on your shoulder is really… unusual.”

The corner of Duncan’s eye twitched.

Duncan knew that more than one person here was paying attention to the pigeon on his shoulder.

If you really thought about it, a pigeon was nothing strange. But coming to a secret meeting while “wearing” a pigeon like this did make things weird.

He could only casually brush it off: “It is my pet. It can help me with many things.”

While he was brushing it off on the surface, Duncan’s thoughts were already racing. Large numbers of Suntists were pouring into the city-state of Pland. This confirmed a suspicion he had had before:

The usually low-key Sun Church had suddenly staged something grand and flashy down in the sewers. These cultists really were preparing something big!

By sneaking in and muddling along this time, he had actually stumbled right onto the right trail!

At the same time, he also understood why the cultists attending this gathering did not hide their faces and were dressed like ordinary citizens.

Back in the sewers, the Sun believers had hidden their identities completely. The lower-level believers only had one-way contact with their superiors. All of that was to resist round after round of purges from the Church and to avoid leaks if traitors appeared inside the Church or key members were captured. It was a desperate choice made by the local Church when they had no other options.

But the rabble in front of him, who had only just gathered in Pland from different city-states, clearly had no such experience yet. After all, they were just cultists, not some disciplined special forces unit.

On the other hand, they had no need for such disguises either. Everyone gathered here was a “countryman” from the same city-state, already familiar with one another. Hiding their identities during meetings would be pointless.

Dressed like ordinary citizens, they could instead run the moment a safe house was exposed and scatter into the crowds of commoners in the Lower City, where management was lax.

Thinking along these lines, Duncan let his gaze sweep over the assembly ground. All of a sudden, he felt a pair of eyes fall on him.

He looked toward the source at once and saw the owner of that gaze.

A petite girl with short black hair was standing a dozen meters away.

The girl wore a black dress trimmed with white lace. Her face was delicate and quiet, and she looked about the same age as Nina. The most striking thing about her, though, was the dark red collar around her neck. A small silver bell hung from it. It looked a little cute, yet also strangely unsettling.

When Duncan turned his gaze toward her, the girl just happened to look away, very casually, as if nothing had happened. Her shift was so smooth that it showed no flaw, but Duncan was sure that earlier stare had definitely come from this young lady.

Why was there such a young child among these cultists?

Doubt rose in Duncan’s heart. He glanced again at the girl’s clothes and bearing… For some reason, he kept feeling that this girl did not fit in with this place at all.

As he was thinking, the creak of hinges suddenly came from nearby. The tall, skinny cult leader ordered the basement door to be shut, then walked to the center of the assembly ground.

All eyes in the room turned to the leader at once. Duncan also pulled his thoughts back and watched the change in the scene. He saw the tall, thin man stand in their gaze with calm confidence, a faint smile on his rather grim face. Then the man took something from his coat and raised it high for everyone to see.

It was a pale gold Sun mask—the very same type of mask that the cult priest who had led the sacrificial ritual in the Underground Assembly Hall had worn before.

“Offer respect to the Lord’s radiance, and silently recite the true words under the Lord’s gaze,” the tall, thin man said loudly, his tone filled with devotion. “Bow your heads to this mask that bears His divine blessing. May the Sun’s Spawn rest their protection within it and help me guide the brothers and sisters gathered here.”

The cultists around him immediately chanted the true God’s name of the Sun in unison. Then they pressed a clenched fist to their brows and bowed their heads in a gesture of reverence. They were not paying respect to the tall, thin man standing in the center of the assembly ground at all, but to that Golden Mask, as if the mask itself were the true body of some higher being and the man holding it was only a vessel.

Duncan also went through the motions among the crowd of cultists, copying their gestures. But he had no idea what the so-called true words were, so he simply muttered a few lines of the multiplication table under his breath and started carefully watching the cultists’ movements, trying to work out the meaning behind each step of the ritual.

The tall, skinny man solemnly put the mask on his own face.

The next second, Duncan immediately sensed that something about the man had… changed.

He could not tell exactly what the feeling was. It was as if, in the instant the other man wore the mask, his whole bearing changed, and as if an extra shadow had appeared behind his figure. Duncan stared at the Golden Sun Mask, shaped in imitation of the Sun, and saw the lines on its surface slowly shifting. In that moment, the mask seemed to come alive. It felt as though some distant and mighty consciousness had projected a faint trace of

its power into it, turning an otherwise ordinary item into something extraordinary.

With that single act of “putting on” the mask and that brief ritual, the ordinary person wearing it had been “sanctified” and turned into a symbol of some kind of divine authority.

The cultists around him cried out in unison: “May our Lord’s radiance endure forever! May our Lord’s path descend upon the mortal world!”

Duncan recited the multiplication table up through the sixes, all while his mind raced, trying to recall.

He had also seen a priest wearing a Golden Mask in that assembly hall in the sewers before. But at that time, the priest had already finished the “putting on” part. On top of that, Duncan still did not understand what was going on around him, and the temporary body he was using had been in bad shape. So he had not realized that this seemingly ordinary Golden Sun Mask had anything special about it, nor had he wondered why the priest wearing it was called an “Envoy” by the common cultists.

Now it seemed… Could this so-called Sun mask actually be a “communication device” used by those “Sun Spawn” hiding outside civilized society, letting them remotely control believers and observe the world? Or, more accurately, was it some kind of mental projection device?

Once he suddenly realized how interesting that item was, Duncan’s gaze on the Golden Mask changed at once.

[This thing… might be fated to end up with me.]

Chapter 73: Incomplete Memories

Duncan quickly drew his gaze back from the Golden Mask that carried the gaze, lowered his eyes slightly like the other cultists around him, and put on the look of someone ready to listen devoutly to the teachings of the rite.

He had not heard anything useful yet; he could not draw that twisted cult entity's attention too early.

And in the instant he lowered his head, that feeling of someone's eyes sweeping over him came again.

Duncan frowned slightly and looked in that direction, following his sense. Sure enough, it was that girl in the black dress with the strange bell on her neck secretly watching him again—and the moment his gaze turned toward her, she quietly turned her head away once more.

This made Duncan even more puzzled.

He was sure he did not know her. In the memories of this body's original master, there was no trace of this girl either. Why would a follower of the Sun he was meeting for the first time keep watching him like this?

[Is it really just because the pigeon on my shoulder looks so special?]

As he let his thoughts run wild like that, he suddenly heard the believer leader's voice from the front. After putting on the Golden Sun Mask, the leader had already become some sort of avatar form of divine authority. Even his voice now sounded deeper and more imposing. Duncan could not

tell whether the man was forcing his tone lower on purpose, or if the mask had truly mixed another consciousness into his voice:

“The benediction is over. The Lord has witnessed our devotion and awe. Grace has already shone upon our souls. Brothers and sisters, be grateful. For every extra day we endure in this harsh, dark world, we draw one day closer to the time when the blazing Sun is reborn and order is reforged.”

The “priest” wearing the Golden Sun Mask spread his arms as he spoke in a highly seductive tone. Then his gaze suddenly fell on a corner among the believers, and his voice turned gentler and more friendly.

“But before we continue with today’s gathering, we must first welcome two comrades. In these harsh times, they were once trapped in darkness, but thanks to the Lord’s guidance, they have returned to the flock… Introduce yourselves. Just briefly is enough.”

[Two comrades?]

Duncan suddenly remembered that this leader had indeed told him earlier that he was not the only unfamiliar face in this assembly ground. Then he looked toward the direction that the leader’s gaze was fixed on—and saw the girl in the black dress.

For some reason, he did not feel surprised.

“You can call me Shirley,” the girl stepped forward half a pace and spoke easily. “Both my parents were believers, but four years ago they were killed by the Deep Sea Church’s lackeys. I have been hiding in the Crossroad District all these years and have never contacted any other brothers and sisters… I am lucky you came.”

Her voice was not loud. She sounded quiet and well-behaved. If he had not seen it with his own eyes, it would have been hard to connect such a child with blood-soaked cultists.

“Welcome back among us, young sister,” the leader nodded, then looked around at the cultists. “Shirley’s parents died in the great purge by the Church four years ago. We found their names on the list from that year. Next is the other comrade.”

The leader’s gaze finally fell on Duncan.

“Duncan, I live in the Lower City,” Duncan had already prepared and stepped forward calmly. “A few days ago, the Deep Sea Church destroyed a sacrificial ritual in the sewers. I am one of the survivors.”

His introduction was very brief, but his attitude was honest and open. And the news about the Deep Sea Church raiding a cult stronghold in the sewers was already widely known. It had taken up the front page of several newspapers. So as soon as he finished speaking, a few cultists nearby began whispering to each other. The leader in the center of the assembly nodded and added: “He is also a comrade who has endured many trials. Even after suffering at the hands of those Deep Sea Church hyenas, he still tried every way to return to the Lord’s embrace. He carries a token that bears the divine blessing, so he can be trusted.”

As the leader finished speaking, the cultists who had not known the details all turned their eyes toward Duncan. Some nodded, some sighed. Duncan kept most of his face covered and recited the multiplication table backwards again…

“The brief introductions are over,” the leader finally moved on to the part Duncan cared about. “Next, I will announce the latest situation.”

Duncan’s ears pricked up at once.

“…At present, many comrades are still converging on this city-state. They include ordinary believers with firm faith, as well as powerful Envoys and

priests. Our strength in this city-state is steadily growing. The day when order is reshaped is drawing near…

“But it cannot be denied that the Deep Sea Church’s lackeys have also reacted. In recent days, the city-state’s authority has been checking outsiders more and more strictly. Several of our gathering points have already been destroyed by the authority. Therefore, all brothers and sisters moving in the city must be extremely careful. The work of collecting sacrificial victims can be slowed down for now. The Lord’s Spawn has already given us instructions. The power we have gathered recently has passed the halfway mark. For what is still lacking, the Spawn will personally make up the rest…”

The cultists around him seemed deeply moved and began praising the Sun God’s mercy and greatness. Duncan immediately thought of the sacrificial ritual he had seen in the sewers before. These cultists really were using that kind of ritual to gather power. And from the sound of it… the hidden manipulators called the “Sun Spawn” were going to take part in person this time?

For now, it seemed the power this group had collected was still not enough, since Pland’s City Hall and the Church had already noticed their movements. But if those Spawn joined the field themselves… the cultists’ plan would probably still go forward!

Just then, he heard the leader continue: “…Our main task now is still to confirm the exact location of the Sun fragment. Remember, our goal is always to bring the true Sun God back into the world, and recovering the lost Sun fragment is the most crucial step!”

Duncan’s heart skipped a beat—Sun fragment? What was that supposed to be?

[If you piled up enough Sun fragments, could you fire a big shot with Aton's Spear?]

He felt the pigeon on his shoulder suddenly grow restless. AI shook its body hard while letting out a low coo from its throat.

Through the link carried by the fire of his spirit form, he could vaguely sense what the pigeon wanted to do.

It wanted to rant, to shout at the top of its lungs, to tell Duncan to grab the Sun-powered battle-axe and muster the troops again.

But it could not speak. Here, it was only a pigeon.

This left it terribly frustrated.

"Quiet," Duncan could only mutter under his breath, rubbing the pigeon's head with the back of his hand to calm it down. At the same time, a cultist standing closer to the leader spoke up: "Can we now at least determine the Sun fragment's rough location? Is there any way to… detect it?"

"The Sun fragment is currently in a dormant state and cannot be detected by any means yet," the leader shook his head. "But the Lord has given us guidance. The fragment should be hiding near Pland's Lower City. Also, since we have new comrades joining us today, I will explain the situation once more:

"Based on the intelligence we already have, the fragment first appeared in the mortal world eleven years ago. It very likely triggered some kind of large-scale extraordinary phenomenon—perhaps a major fire, perhaps abnormal high heat across an entire block, or perhaps mass spontaneous combustion or shared hallucinations. This is the direction of our current investigation.

"The city-state's authority keeps detailed records on extraordinary incidents over the years. The great God-Touched are already trying to seek out those

records. Among the ordinary people living in the Lower City, some may also still remember the ‘strange events’ that happened here eleven years ago. Our task is to gather clues of this kind in order to infer the Sun fragment’s location.

“But remember, all such inquiries must be done with extreme care. Although the authority’s control over the Lower City has always been lax, the Deep Sea Church’s hyenas sometimes have an unusually sharp nose… They are already on alert.”

As the leader explained the current situation to the surrounding congregants, Duncan’s mind was also racing. He paid special attention to that time point of “eleven years ago.” According to the leader, eleven years ago was when the extraordinary object known as the “Sun fragment” first appeared in the world. But Duncan noticed that date because of something else.

Eleven years ago, Nina had been only six years old when she lost her parents.

It seemed to have been because of a fire.

Was that really just a coincidence? Could there be such a perfect coincidence?

Duncan tried hard to sort through the messy, broken memories in his head, but more than half of them had vanished along with this body’s original master. No matter how hard he tried, he could only recall one or two vague fragments: the original master of this body charging out of the flames, holding his dying niece in his arms; a building he could no longer clearly see burning fiercely and collapsing behind him; and, in the distance, city streets twisted and dim like a mirage, with countless frantic people screaming and running through them…

Chapter 74: There’s a Mole, Cancel the Deal

Duncan still failed to dig up any more memories from his mind.

Even though the original master of this body had truly cared about Nina, and everything related to Nina had once been the deepest memory in his mind, years of illness and heavy drinking and drug abuse had ruined it. When the cultist named Ron let out his last breath, there had not been many warm memories of his family left in his numb head.

There was only one thing he could be sure of: eleven years ago there really had been a great fire, and it had happened in the Lower City—that fire had taken the lives of Nina’s birth parents and forever changed the path of that child’s life.

It might have been a coincidence, but there was an even greater chance that what had happened was really tied to the “Sun fragment” that these Suntists were searching for.

If that was the case, then a fragment of the Sun had appeared by accident in the city and started a fire. Innocent citizens lost their lives. A child became an orphan in the flames. And years later, that child’s only remaining relative had fallen and become one of the cultists who followed that same fragment of the Sun…

In the dark, it felt like some cursed fate circling around the Sun, trapped in its pull like gravity.

Right then, one of the cultists around him suddenly spoke, cutting off Duncan's thoughts: "These days I asked around among the residents nearby. I never heard about any famous big fire in the Lower City eleven years ago… but someone did mention that back then a factory had a leak. Poisonous gas from the storage tanks spread across several blocks. A lot of people fell into hallucinations and went mad. That incident even made the papers at the time."

Duncan raised his head in surprise and saw that the speaker was an ordinary-looking female cultist.

Before he had time to think over what she said, he noticed the cult leader's gaze turn toward him: "Brother, you just happen to be a local here. Do you know anything about this?"

Duncan froze for a moment and suddenly realized that he had become the focus of the whole scene. To these out-of-town cultists who were trying to gather information, a "local who lived in Pland's Lower City" was without doubt a great source.

Feeling the gazes around him, he thought for a second and quickly came up with an answer: "Eleven years ago I wasn't living here yet, so I don't know the details. But I did hear people mention the factory leak…"

While he fobbed them off like this, he looked at the woman who had spoken earlier: "So there really was no big fire in the Lower City eleven years ago?"

"At least from what I found out, that's how it is," the woman nodded. "According to what I heard, Pland's Lower City hasn't had any large fires for at least twenty years… There are small ones, like kitchen fires, but those obviously don't count."

Duncan blinked and said nothing.

He clearly remembered that Nina's parents had died in a great fire eleven years ago. In the fragments in his mind, there was even the scene where "he" carried Nina out of the burning building.

Where did it go wrong? Did something get scrambled when this body inherited its memories? Or had that fire back then not happened in the Lower City at all? Or… was it simply because this cultist here had failed to find out the truth…

A faint doubt rose in his heart. Because this matter involved Nina and "himself", he could not help but pay more attention to it. And just then, he heard another voice from across the room. It was the girl named Shirley: "That factory leak eleven years ago… was it the one in the Sixth District?"

"The Sixth District? Mm… that sounds right," the woman nodded. "They say the impact was huge at the time. The chemicals left many people with long-term side effects. Quite a lot of residents in the Lower City still remember it today."

A few cultists nearby nodded in agreement when they heard this. It looked like they had found out more or less the same thing.

"A factory leak…" The leader standing in the center of the gathering suddenly broke the silence. His deep, commanding voice cut through the cultists' chatter. "An apparent industrial accident is very likely an supernatural incident disguised by The authority. And it happened exactly at the Node eleven years ago… This is a very important clue. Next we will investigate in this direction and see whether this so-called factory leak points to the holy fragment of the Sun."

The cultists present all nodded and accepted the order at once. Then the masked leader continued: "In addition, we must not only pay attention to supernatural events that happened in the Lower City eleven years ago. We must also watch the unusual things in the city-state of Pland in recent times.

“Even though the fragment of the Sun is still asleep for now, the day of its awakening is close. Its activity is growing every day. Four years ago, our brothers and sisters in the Church tried to wake that fragment ahead of time. Their attempt failed, and the failure of the ritual even drew the furious slaughter of the Deep Sea Church. But that attempt was not completely useless—the stimulus of the awakening ritual deepened the connection between the fragment of the Sun and the Mortal Realm. That is enough for it to gain the power to affect the Mortal Realm for a short time before it fully awakens, and that may help us find it.

“In the near future, pay close attention to the newspapers in the city-state, and to every rumor in the streets and alleys. Any event that looks unusual may point to the fragment of the Sun. Do not let any clue slip past. Understood?”

The cultists all lowered their heads and accepted the command with respect. Duncan, however, focused on another key Node the leader had mentioned:

Four years ago!

Four years ago, the Deep Sea Church in the city-state of Pland had indeed wiped out the largest Sun heretic stronghold in the city in one stroke. They said the scale of the incident had shaken the whole city. It had also been the battle that established the fame of the city-state’s current Inquisitor, Vanna—and after that, the Suntists in this city had never recovered, even up to today.

All this time, Duncan had only known that surface-level information. Now it seemed the truth behind it all was that the Suntists in the city had tried to wake a sleeping fragment of the Sun ahead of time?!

Without noticing it, a chain of truths that had been hidden in the past unfolded before Duncan’s eyes. He quickly pieced together the fragments of

information in his mind and thought about how to get more out of these cultists. But right then, a strange smell suddenly slipped into his nose.

It smelled like burning sulfur mixed with the sour, acrid stench of some chemical.

The next second, the other ordinary cultists around them smelled it too. Some looked at each other, as if searching for the source of the stench. The leader standing in the center of the gathering reacted at once. He suddenly pulled from his coat a charm amulet modeled after the Sun—the very same kind of Sun charm amulet Duncan carried. Its surface was burning with illusory, half-transparent flames.

The sharp, acrid smell was coming from that fire.

“Filthy impurities… the flame has been deceived!” The leader glanced at the burning Sun charm amulet, his voice suddenly filled with both shock and anger. “There is a heretic hiding among us!”

The room burst into an uproar at once. Duncan’s first reaction was that he had been exposed. He didn’t know how, but it seemed the Sun charm amulet on the leader had finally recognized him as a “heretic” who did not believe in the Sun at all.

Thinking of this, he let out a small sigh and was about to release the dove. But before he could move, he heard another sigh come from across the room—

The sigh came from the girl in the black dress, the maiden named Shirley. She shook her head in regret: “I knew A-Dog wasn’t reliable. The disguise couldn’t even last three hours.”

Before her voice even fell, a mass of pitch-black flame suddenly exploded into being at the girl’s side!

The flame was born out of thin air. It had the shape of fire, yet was black as shadow. It ignited on the girl's arm and, in one second, spread across almost a third of her body. In the next moment, Shirley's right side looked like fuel for the black fire. It crackled as it burned. The flowing flame streamed downward, the part in midair twisting into a black chain, and the part that fell to the floor condensing in a heartbeat into a bony, burning monster!

It was a pitch-black hellhound, a huge dog more than half as tall as a grown man. Its body looked pieced together from countless twisted, piled-up bones. Where there should have been flesh, there was only burning black fire and writhing shadows. Its skull was jagged and ferocious. Where its eyes should have been were empty sockets filled only with blood-red mist, packed with endless hunger and malice!

A black chain extended from the huge dog's neck all the way to Shirley's arm, faintly merging with the girl's body.

"A Abyssal Hound… a summoner from the Cult of Annihilation?!" The leader in the center of the gathering was both shocked and furious at the sight. "What is the meaning of this?! Are you people who worship the Abyssal Deep planning to start a war with the Suntists?!"

Chapter 75: Beaten into a Pile

Seeing how things suddenly turned out, Duncan, who had been about to stand up openly and confess that “the mole is me”, quietly stepped back again instead. He switched to the mindset of a bystander watching a show and looked at the situation in the hall.

So he was not the only mole here after all—the girl in the black dress had felt out of place to him from the start. At first Duncan had only thought her quiet, very young air did not fit this cult gathering, and that was why she gave him that feeling. He had never expected it to be like this.

He noticed two terms the leader had just used: Abyssal Hound, and Cult of Annihilation.

The Abyssal Hound obviously meant the huge black skeletal dog the girl had summoned. The Cult of Annihilation, on the other hand, did not sound like some lively civic group that could be registered openly at City Hall. This girl really was not a follower of the Sun at all. She belonged to some other cult?!

Just how many strange dark cults were still hiding in the gutters of this world?

While Duncan’s thoughts were turning, the girl who had summoned the Abyssal Hound had already lifted the black chain on her arm a little. She kept a guarded stance while her eyes swept over the hall. There seemed to be a mocking smile at the corner of her mouth: “Cult of Annihilation…

Sorry, I don’t have much to do with them. Unlike you bastards who have to be some Eldritch God’s lapdogs to sleep at night, I only work for myself!”

“You can’t fool anyone with that excuse. Only the Cult of Annihilation knows how to summon the horrors of the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea. I advise you to give up, heretic. You are standing on the Sun God’s ground. Even the Abyssal Hound’s spells can’t save you here!” The leader in the center of the hall stared hard at Shirley. His voice was low and full of threat. “Speak. What are you people trying to do?! Annihilation and the Sun are not allies, but we have never been enemies either. Why did you disguise yourself and sneak into our holy gathering?”

“I only wanted to dig a bit of intel out of you mutts’ not-so-bright heads, that’s all—” Shirley’s mouth curled up. The chain linked to her body suddenly gave off a series of clanking sounds. The strange metal links writhed slowly like living things. “And I said it already, I’m not from the Cult of Annihilation…!”

Before the girl could finish, a series of crackling sounds suddenly rose all around them. The oil lamps set in every corner of the room seemed driven by some unknown power and burst into blazing flames all at once!

The bright flames from the oil lamps lit the whole basement as bright as day. Above each lamp, a small fireball rose and floated up. Each fireball looked like a tiny Sun, and they began to radiate a vast power. At some point, the leader in the center of the hall had also gripped his Sun charm amulet with all his strength. The amulet’s sharp, flame-shaped spikes cut into his palm. Blood seeped into the charm amulet and burned like oil, setting his entire hand ablaze as he held it. The fire on his hand echoed from afar with the suddenly changed oil lamps.

Clearly, this seasoned cult priest had only been stalling with a few sentences. While Shirley was not paying attention, he had already activated

some kind of supernatural power.

“Give up and surrender, heretic.” A threatening voice came from under the golden Sun mask. “The power of the Sun God has already sealed this place. I know the abilities of you Annihilators. You can borrow spells from the demons you summon and use those spells to harm others. The Abyssal Hound’s own Shadow Breath is indeed fearsome—but this place is sealed now. You and your dog cannot borrow any power from the Abyssal Deep or the Deep Sea!”

Duncan’s fingers moved slightly inside his pocket. He wondered whether he should step in to help. It might look like two groups of cultists tearing at each other’s throats, but the girl named Shirley might know some things. And right now she clearly seemed outnumbered.

Just then, the leader wearing the golden Sun mask stretched toward Shirley the hand that gripped the Sun’s burning emblem. The voice from under the mask was low and tempting, as if some unseen power was mixed into his words: “Give up your resistance. Convert in the Sun God’s domain and then tell me everything you know. The merciful Sun will forgive your sins… Kneel, young sister… You cannot use your spells…”

Yet Shirley seemed deaf to the Sun priest’s threat. She only turned her head to glance at the burning oil lamps, then at the Suntists around her who had already drawn short swords, daggers, and even revolvers. She asked calmly: “It must be pretty hard for you to keep this Warding Field up, right?”

The Sun priest gave a cold snort: “Hmph, this is the power granted by my Lord…”

Before he could finish, the girl in the black dress suddenly moved!

Shirley suddenly took a big step forward. Her right arm, wrapped in black fire, swung up. The black iron chain howled through the air, and the

Abyssal Hound at its end was lifted high as she whirled it around. The giant dog, several times larger than an ordinary hound, was swung in a full circle with monstrous strength and then crashed down with a terrible boom, slamming into the Sun priest's chest.

The crisp sound of breaking bones rang out. The Sun priest had been focusing all his strength on maintaining the barrier, so he had no time to react at all before being hit by the flying dog. He shot backwards like a ragged sack and slammed into the wall opposite, then stopped moving.

Duncan: "…"

He really had not seen that coming.

It all happened in a flash. The sudden turn left every cultist there stunned. The Suntists were still waiting for their leader's order. In the next second they saw their boss flying away, and right after that, the howling of the chain in midair tore through the air again!

Shirley raised her arm again. The black chain clattered. With another burst of monstrous strength, she swung the Abyssal Hound up like a meteor hammer. The giant dog traced a terrifying arc through the air. After several loud crashes—bang, bang, bang—several more cultists spat blood and flew backward!

This time, the cultists finally reacted. Ignoring their shock, they all roared and rushed at the girl who was lifting the chain again. More than a dozen daggers and blades swung through the air. In answer, Shirley spun the Abyssal Hound in a full circle and cursed at the top of her lungs: "Go to hell and keep your damned god company! You mongrel trash!"

The giant dog tore through the air. Every cultist it hit flew back with snapped bones and torn muscles. Shirley's skill with this living meteor hammer was almost supernatural. For a while, all Duncan could see on the

field were chains whipping through the air, the giant dog howling, and the girl darting and spinning among them, her hand rising and the dog crashing down again and again…

Right then, several gunshots suddenly rang out!

The Suntists who carried revolvers had finally found an opening. After realizing that there was no way to take down the brute-strength girl in close combat, they pulled their triggers without hesitation.

Brass bullets cut through the air. Two hit the chain, bursting into brief bright sparks. The others drilled one after another into Shirley's body.

"Ugh…" The girl's body suddenly swayed. The impact and pain of the bullets tearing into her made her lose her footing for a moment. Yet in the very next second, just as the cultists thought the tide had turned, the howling of the chain rang out again.

"A-Dog! Block my sense of pain!"

The Abyssal Hound spinning through the air let out a chaotic roar. In the next instant, it smashed straight into a cultist with a gun and sent him flying. His head hit a pillar in the distance, and he instantly turned into a fresh mini version of Alice…

In the center of the hall, the whirling "meteor dog" grew even more fierce than before!

Duncan quietly took two steps back, lowering his presence as much as he could while he waited for it all to be over.

Right now he mainly worried about blood splattering on him—he had changed into these clothes only today. It would be hard to explain things to Nina when he got back.

As for that woman warrior who wielded a fine "meteor dog"…

She probably did not need his help.

She was in great shape.

The entire fight did not actually last very long. The black-dressed girl's whirling hunting hound hit hard and moved fast. This basement, where there was no way to escape, was like her own private killing ground. Duncan just stood in the corner silently reciting the multiplication table a second time. Before he finished, the battle was already over.

When every cultist had been beaten into one big pile, the basement finally grew quiet.

Shirley finally stopped. She held tight to the iron chain that bound the Abyssal Hound and stood in the middle of the room, panting hard. Suddenly, her eyes caught the figure standing in the corner by the wall.

She had finally noticed Duncan, the last "cultist" left in this gathering.

Even though she felt stunned and puzzled by this strange "cultist's" calm look, Shirley still did not hesitate. She dragged the dog along and walked toward her last target.

Her hostility was plain to see.

Chapter 76: The Hound Sees Through the Human Heart

Watching Shirley stride toward him with murder in her eyes, Duncan could not help letting out a sigh. [So in the end, this mess still landed on my head.]

He was not very nervous. To be fair, he knew he had almost no combat experience, while the young lady in front of him looked like a female warrior who could charge into Longridge Slope seven times and come back out again. But he still did not panic at all.

First, he had a dove that specialized in Delayed Slash. AI's power took effect instantly within its range and triggered faster than a gun. If Shirley really swung the dog at him, she would probably be beaten by the dove's high-ping attack while still in midair and die from packet loss.

Second, he controlled the spirit form flame that had strange effects on all supernatural things. This fire could even control the Vanished, so this Abyssal Hound before him was probably not harder to handle than that pile of monsters on the Vanished, right? At worst, he would let the flame possess it and coil around its whole body. After that, it would be his area of expertise: [Young lady, I can tell your dog and I are destined to meet…]

Last, and most important—this body was not his real body anyway.

Right now, he was only using an avatar form. From a biological point of view, this avatar form seemed alive, but in essence it was still just a corpse driven by Ghost power. Duncan did not need this body to stay

physiologically intact for it to move. Just like the previous avatar form in the sewers that kept moving even after it lost its heart, he only needed this body to “exist” so he could keep using it.

He even suspected that even if his current avatar form was chopped into pieces, he could still control it to go home in batches…

The only thing that worried him was that if Shirley smashed all his bones with a meteor-hound strike, how he should explain to Nina afterward why her Uncle’s bones were suddenly so special…

So he stood there calmly, watching the girl in the black dress walk up to him. The black iron chain in her hand swung in the air, and that bizarre, terrifying Abyssal Hound followed at her side with an odd, hard-to-read gait, slowly padding along beside its master.

Because of the fierce battle earlier, the girl’s arms and cheeks were stained with blood. This completely broke the first impression of a quiet, well-behaved girl and instead made her look eerie and dangerous.

“You’re really not afraid. You really are strange.” Shirley stopped two or three meters in front of Duncan, frowning at the “Suntist” in front of her. At the same time, her right hand slowly, quietly lifted. “Have you given up resisting?”

Duncan thought for a moment: “If I say I’m not with them, would you believe me?”

As he spoke, he rubbed his fingers quietly inside his pocket, letting the phantom spirit form flame slowly wander between his clothes and skin, in case this young lady decided to start swinging the dog the moment she got upset.

Shirley froze for a second. An “are you kidding me” expression slowly appeared on her blood-stained face. “Do you think I—”

Before she finished, the Abyssal Hound beside her suddenly spoke human words. A hoarse, low voice came from its throat woven of bones: “I believe him.”

“Huh… huh?” Shirley stared in shock at her summoned creature. “Dog, did I just smash your brain? This guy—”

“Please wait a moment,” the Abyssal Hound shook its head, then, under Duncan’s blank gaze, walked off to the side, stretched its neck, and went: “Uuurgh—”

The extremely loud retching echoed through the blood-stained basement. The terrifying demon from the Abyssal Deep, from the Deep Sea, turned its insides upside down on the spot. It vomited up clouds of choking, acrid black flame, ash, and pitch-black slime like acid. The concrete floor hissed as the corrupted stuff ate into it, and within seconds a large pit sank into the ground.

Duncan watched the scene with a blank face, wondering if he had just found a weakness in Shirley’s fighting power—this young lady was strong, ruthless, and her fighting style was weird and hard to guard against, but she clearly was not good at long battles.

The key was her way of fighting: a person could take it, but the dog could not.

So the atmosphere in the room stayed awkward like that for two or three minutes. When the Abyssal Hound finally stopped vomiting, Duncan could not help leaning over to look at it. “…Are you okay?”

The hound instantly lowered its head. Its tail, made of coiled bones, tucked tightly between its legs. “Thank you for your concern. I hope my rude display did not offend your eyes. Do you have any other orders? If not, we will take our leave…”

Duncan had not even had time to react to what was wrong with this dog when Shirley cried out first: “Dog, are you really okay? Did I actually smash your head just now?! You are never this polite when you talk to humans. No one who stands in front of you ever lasts more than ten seconds before you start cursing their mother…”

By now Duncan had faintly caught on. He suddenly looked at the vicious, terrifying-looking Abyssal Hound, and his eyes grew serious.

From the few words he had heard earlier from the Sun priest, this “great hound” was some kind of demon summoned from the Abyssal Deep, from the Deep Sea. For the moment, he did not care what the so-called Cult of Annihilation was, or what strange things filled the Abyssal Deep, or why people could even summon a dog out of it. One thing was at least clear:

This “dog” was afraid of him. This demon from the Abyssal Deep, from the Deep Sea… it probably had a kind of “sight” very different from that of an ordinary person.

“Do you know who I am?” Duncan asked calmly. “Have you seen me before?”

“I don’t, I don’t,” the Abyssal Hound said without even raising its head. “I truly don’t know you… but you are definitely a big shot, no doubt about that…”

Duncan frowned and asked: “In your eyes, I don’t look like a human, do I?”

The Abyssal Hound hesitated. It raised its head with great care and glanced at Duncan, then said, hesitating: “You… do look like one… and also don’t look like one…”

Duncan withdrew his gaze and looked at Shirley.

The girl in the black dress was staring at them in shock and doubt. She had finally put away her first wave of hostility. In its place was thick

bewilderment and wariness.

This young lady seemed a bit reckless, but she was clearly not stupid. After her “pet dog” showed such abnormal reactions again and again, even the most impulsive person would cool down at this point and start to sense that something was wrong.

She quietly tightened the chain between her and the Abyssal Hound as she stepped half a step back without drawing notice, and watched Duncan carefully. “You just said you’re not with them…”

“That’s right.” Duncan spread his hands. “You might not believe it, but I also sneaked in here to gather information…”

“I believe you,” Shirley said crisply.

This time it was Duncan’s turn to be surprised. He suddenly realized that the impression this girl gave him kept changing. At first, from her looks, he had thought she was a quiet, well-behaved child, but then she showed a violent, bloody side. Just now he had thought she was a simple-minded reckless type, yet now she adapted to the situation and backed down even faster than he had imagined…

[What kind of family raises a child like this?]

With that strange thought circling in his mind, Duncan also felt a little thrown off by how straightforward her attitude was. He steadied himself before asking: “Back at the gathering, why did you look at me twice in a row?”

“Dog kept watching you,” Shirley answered, a bit unwilling but still cooperative. “I was just curious and followed his gaze for a couple of looks…”

“Dog? This one?” Duncan frowned and glanced at the pitch-black Skeletal Hound. “Earlier I heard that priest mention the Cult of Annihilation—is that

a church that worships the Abyssal Deep Sea? What is your relationship with this Cult of Annihilation?”

“I have nothing to do with them!” Shirley said at once, with extra emphasis. “If they worship the Abyssal Deep Sea, that’s their business. Dog and I know each other for other reasons!”

Duncan’s eyes fell on the chain between the girl and the Abyssal Hound.

From the information he had just gotten, worshipping the Abyssal Deep Sea, being able to summon demons from the Abyssal Deep, and normally using those demons’ power as spells in battle, all seemed to be trademarks of the Cult of Annihilation. That Sun priest had judged Shirley that way only because she had summoned a Abyssal Hound—although he had suffered a “flying dog meteor hammer” for that wrong guess, Duncan still believed that at least under normal conditions this information was correct.

The only problem was this strange girl in front of him.

She seemed very resistant to anyone linking her with cultists—even though she had a hound from the Abyssal Deep, from the Deep Sea.

“Fine, then you have nothing to do with them,” Duncan shook his head and asked again. “So why are you here? What are you investigating?”

Shirley pressed her lips together. She clearly did not want to answer that question, but the tense signals pouring off the hound beside her made her understand that this ordinary-looking middle-aged man was probably extremely dangerous. She had better cooperate.

“I…”

Shirley opened her mouth, but the moment she spoke, a loud blast exploded in the basement. A blazing fireball suddenly flew in from the side!

Chapter 77: Thoughts About Fire

The blast roared through the basement and a blazing fireball suddenly flew in from the side—but before it got close, Duncan had already reacted.

His senses were much faster than his body. The instant the anomalous energy appeared in the basement, he sensed something was wrong. Now he did not have time to think and raised his hand to block on instinct!

A hint of heat came from his fingertips. The next second, the erupting spirit form fire surged into the fireball with a backdraft-like blast. Duncan caught the burning mass that had shot out from the corner of the basement out of thin air. The blazing flames were almost instantly dyed a ghostly green. The explosive energy turned obedient in a moment and began to burn quietly in his hand.

Holding the fireball that had turned into a ghost-green spirit flame, Duncan slowly turned his head toward the direction of the attack.

The instant his gaze moved away, the Abyssal Hound called Dog suddenly leaped back. A rift churning with countless shadows and black mist appeared out of nowhere where it landed. It jumped in without hesitation, and the black iron chain dragged Shirley along with it. Before she flew into the rift, she spat hard to the side. Several blood-stained bullets landed on the ground.

In the next second, the girl and the hound vanished from the basement.

Hearing the noise, Duncan turned back in surprise, only to see the hem of the girl’s dress disappearing into the rift. This strange man-and-dog duo had

run off while he glanced away.

[I still had a whole pile of questions left to ask!]

And all because some cultist with abnormal vitality suddenly launched a sneak attack.

Duncan felt a subtle irritation rise in him. He looked again toward where the fireball had come from and saw the cult priest wearing the Sun mask slumped crookedly against the corner of the wall, holding up his arm with his last breath. He seemed stunned that the fireball he had summoned with all his strength had not only been caught out of thin air but even had its control taken away. Even through the Golden Sun Mask, Duncan could see the dull stare in his eyes.

“Not finishing off an enemy after a fight is a really bad habit…”

Duncan’s face darkened. Muttering to himself about a certain dog-swinging girl who did not know how to finish an enemy, he slowly walked toward the badly wounded but still living cult priest.

He was still holding the quiet, ghost-green flame ball in his hand. The power leaking from it silently spread through the basement.

With each step Duncan took, the oil lamps and torches set around the basement seemed to feel some strange call. The dancing flames were dyed ghostly green one after another. In this eerie light that crept closer and closer, the Sun priest wearing the mask finally felt a fear stronger than ever before—

He felt his link to the god the Sun quickly weaken. As each lamp was “seized”, the Sun’s gaze melted away from his soul like snow in spring!

Under this enormous terror, a trembling voice finally came from behind the mask: “You… you’re not an ordinary heretic. What are you…”

When the last lamp turned into ghost-green soul fire, Duncan stopped in front of the priest. He lowered his head slightly. His face looked especially grim in the light of the spirit form fire. “I hadn’t finished my questions, and you cut me off. That’s very rude. Didn’t your mother teach you better?”

As he spoke, he also noticed the condition of the Sun priest.

He felt he had wronged Shirley—half of this cultist’s chest had already collapsed, and his broken ribs might have pierced his heart and lungs. It was obviously a fatal injury, so in theory there was no need at all to finish him off.

The priest was still alive only because some stronger, stranger power was keeping him hanging on. That was probably the “god the Sun” these cultists kept talking about.

Even so, Duncan could clearly see that life was rapidly flowing out of the priest’s body. Each breath grew weaker. It was only a matter of time before he died.

He did not know why, but it was clear that the Sun’s divine blessing was quickly leaving this priest.

“It seems the Sun’s divine blessing isn’t very reliable,” Duncan shook his head with a sigh. “Your lord has already abandoned you.”

He had only spoken casually, but he had not expected that sentence to provoke the half-dead priest. The man’s eyes bulged with rage, and driven by huge anger he burst out with his last bit of strength. Under Duncan’s surprised gaze, he suddenly pulled a blood-stained strip of cloth from his sleeve!

“I offer this body to my lord! May the Sacred shroud purify the heretic before me!”

The priest shouted. Filthy clots of blood and bits of organ splattered across the Golden Sun Mask. He raised the “Sacred shroud” high in his hand and offered the most complete and crazed sacrifice to his lord—

He sacrificed all of himself, only to ignite the Sacred shroud and die together with this heretic who had stolen control of the flames!

Yet Duncan only watched this final crazed sacrificial rite with a calm gaze —although he had indeed been startled when the priest suddenly pulled something from his sleeve, once he saw what it was, he relaxed completely.

It was the same strange strip of cloth the man had used earlier, when Duncan first entered the gathering, to verify his “identity as a fellow believer”—he just had not expected that this strip also carried a grand name like “Sacred shroud”.

Just as Duncan expected, the Sacred shroud stayed perfectly still. The cult priest’s most extreme final sacrifice did not wake any sacred miracle at all.

A hint of confusion showed in the eyes under the mask. The cult priest forced his body upright and stared in despair at the silent sacred relic in his hand. He spat another mouthful of filthy blood in stubborn disbelief. “I offer this body to my lord…”

“I guess what you really want is this.”

Duncan could not bear to watch anymore. He shook his head and pointed at the blood-soaked strip of cloth.

The next second, a tuft of ghost-green flame burst into being!

The spirit form fire ignited the Sacred shroud, ignited the filthy blood the cult priest had coughed up, and ignited the flesh of this madman. In the spirit flame, the priest let out a roar full of shock and rage. “No, no, no… it shouldn’t be like this… the lord will not abandon me, the lord… the lord will punish you, heretic… who are you?!”

In the roaring flames, the cult priest's voice finally grew weak and faded. The life force propped up by supernatural power still could not withstand this fire that burned the soul directly—or rather, it was exactly because of that supernatural power that he turned to ash under the backlash of the spirit flame.

The spirit form fire finally faded away. The Sun priest leaning in the corner had been completely burned to nothing. Only a scattered pile of clothes and the Golden Sun Mask, shaped in imitation of the Sun, were left on the spot.

Even the so-called "Sacred shroud" had burned to ash in the fire after serving as the "medium".

Duncan frowned.

To be honest, this was not the first time he had seen a corpse—the "sacrificial victims" in the underground caves before, and that priest who had been "sacrificed", had already toughened his nerves. At this moment he was only a bit surprised.

Normally, his spirit form fire only acted on supernatural items. He had tested this in many ways while on the Vanished—any supernatural object burned by the fire would be "seized" and turned into Captain Duncan's property. If something was not supernatural, then even a piece of paper would not be affected by the spirit form fire.

Just now, the spirit form fire had produced real burning. That was because he had triggered it on purpose—he was worried that the cultist would really do something with that Sacred shroud, so out of caution he ordered the Sacred shroud to burn itself. From the result, the Sacred shroud had indeed obeyed the order faithfully.

He had not expected, though, that the spreading flames would also burn the cult priest to ash. That did not match the conclusion he had gotten from his

earlier tests.

It was normal for the Sacred shroud to burn away, because it was an supernatural item and would be affected by the spirit form fire.

It was also normal that the cult priest's clothes were left behind untouched, because those clothes were clearly "ordinary things". To ordinary things, the spirit form fire was like a phantom in another world and had no effect at all—unless the clothing itself was enchanted or woven with some supernatural material.

It was also normal that the Golden Sun Mask remained completely intact. Duncan was very interested in this obviously supernatural item, so as soon as the fire began to spread he had given an order to keep the mask from being damaged.

Then… why had this cultist been burned to ash by the spirit form fire?

Confused, Duncan squatted down and carefully examined the dark gray ash.

It looked about the same as the ash left after the Sacred shroud burned.

Duncan had never tested his spirit form fire on a living person before, let alone used the flames on purpose to take a life. This cult priest should count as the first real victim of his fire.

At least, the first real victim while he was consciously in control.

Slowly, a bold idea suddenly rose in Duncan's mind.

Could it be that… mortals who had received "divine blessing" from worshipping a specific deity could also be treated as "supernatural items"?

Chapter 78: Cleanup Work and a Good citizen’s Duty

Duncan’s thoughts led nowhere, because he had no idea where to find a second Suntist who was still breathing to test his theory on.

This kind of thing depended on luck.

Duncan slowly stood up. One by one, the pale green spirit flame lamps in the basement flickered in the still air. In their wavering light and shadow, his thoughts spread out again.

A cultist who believed in a God and had received divine blessing might be seen by the fire of his spirit form as an “extraordinary item”. Then… what about an ordinary person?

When this flame burned on an ordinary person, could it do anything beyond those surface “light and shadow effects”? If not, then how deep did one have to believe in a God before the flame would treat them as a valid “extraordinary target”? It could burn cultists who believed in an Eldritch God, so what about people who worshiped the True Gods?

Duncan calmly watched the dim lamps in the room, then suddenly gave a faint smile.

“They are human.”

So his thoughts stopped there. He did not follow this line any further.

This flame was a powerful force. Power itself was not a sin, but a weak will could easily invite corruption. Ever since he had found out that he held a power beyond imagination, Duncan kept reminding himself of this. No matter how famous “Captain Duncan” became, no matter how strong the fire of his spirit form was, he had to always watch the limits of himself as a “human”.

He could not treat people as things just to test or control his power, even in this strange world, even if those he faced were not always “human” in the standard sense.

Striking in a fight was one thing. Looking for the weak to test his blade on, just to satisfy his curiosity, was another.

Duncan let out a soft breath. He looked at the ghostly green ball of flame still burning in his hand, then waved his hand to dismiss it.

The flame obeyed him faithfully and vanished into the air without a sound.

Duncan smiled. He was, and would always be, the master of this flame.

After the fire of his spirit form faded, the basement quickly shifted from eerie back to normal. One after another, the pale green lamps returned to the bright, clear state they had at the start. Duncan looked around at the messy scene and thought about what to do next.

That strange girl named Shirley was gone, and it seemed she had used some kind of extraordinary method to escape. He knew nothing in that field and had no idea where to look for her. It was truly a pity.

He still had many questions for her. Now it seemed there would be no chance.

But Duncan still felt that he might run into that girl again someday. This was not a baseless guess. Her goal was clearly to cause trouble for these Suntists and to pry something out of them. Lately, the activity of Suntists in

the city-state of Pland was at its peak. Countless similar gatherings were going on in the dark. With Shirley and “Dog” and their way of doing things…

They were bound to stir up some lively, big trouble sooner or later.

Duncan had the Sun emblem on him, whose authority he had seized. It let him sense the activities of Suntists in the city. For now, its sensing range did not seem very large, but as long as he strolled around the city when he had nothing else to do, he might bump into some new fun.

As for this mess here, Duncan had no interest in cleaning it up.

He only picked up the golden Sun mask left behind by the Sun priest from the pile of ashes on the floor and carefully wiped off the ash and dust on its surface. This was his trophy, and he meant to take it back to the Vanished to study.

That priest had been burned very clean. Every item on him that touched the supernatural field had turned to ash. The Sun mask was the only “relic” he had left in this world.

“…A palm-sized charm amulet is one thing. This thing might be a bit too big…” Duncan muttered, weighing the Sun mask in his hands. “And if I run into professionals from the Deep Sea Church, they might use some special method to detect it…”

It would be hard to carry this mask on him and safely bring it back to the antique shop. Even if he managed to get it there, Nina might find it, and that would surely cause trouble.

The best way was to send it straight to a completely safe place.

As he thought, Duncan looked back at the pigeon perched on his shoulder. A brand-new test idea came to him. If he did not go along, could this pigeon

travel through the Spirit Realm on its own and take things back to the Vanished?

The pigeon tilted its head and stared at Duncan, eye to eye: “Big hammer for eighty, small hammer for forty!”

Duncan laughed: “Think of it as working overtime. Later I’ll find a way to get you some fries on the ship. Try and see if you can take this mask to the Vanished by yourself.”

The pigeon flapped its wings at once. As it flew toward the mask in Duncan’s hand, it let out that sharp, feminine voice of its: “I wanted to say no, but you are offering far too much!”

Before the words even finished, light and shadow flashed in front of him. The pigeon and the mask vanished from his sight at the same time. In the perception deep in his mind, he clearly felt AI’s presence suddenly appear in the captain’s cabin on the Vanished.

The delay was barely even a second!

This pigeon was so fast! So it could teleport items this quickly?

As Duncan was still marveling in his heart, his vision blurred. AI, in her bone-pigeon form, sprang out of thin air and landed on his shoulder. The bird flapped its wings, and her undead body returned to that of a white dove. She proudly lifted her head: “teleportation successful!”

Seeing the state she was in when she popped back out, Duncan nodded to himself. Things made sense now. Of course the bone pigeon was faster than AI.

Then he straightened his clothes and checked that there were no suspicious bloodstains left on him and that he had left no trace at the scene. In fact, he had not touched anything since he came in, afraid of leaving fingerprints or

the like. Only then did he carefully use his coat to pad his fingers, open the iron door, and go back out through the stairway he had used to come down.

The Sun, bound by two rings of runes, had already sunk close to the horizon. Gorgeous evening clouds spread over the uneven roofs of the Lower City. High in the sky above the sunset, that faint streak of the Pale Rift had begun to show itself.

One look at the sky made Duncan drop the idea of continuing to investigate the city. Nina would be coming home from school soon.

That child's "Uncle Duncan" had only just gotten better. He could not stay out all night now.

Duncan quickly left the abandoned factory and walked toward the main road along the route he remembered. He passed through twisted little alleys and through an area where pipes crossed, sewage flowed, and strange smells filled the air. At last he began to faintly hear the sounds of traffic from far away.

The sky was not fully dark yet. He should still be able to catch the last bus.

But Duncan suddenly stopped.

At the intersection not far ahead, he saw four people in uniform. Two of them wore dark blue constable uniforms with epaulettes, with batons and revolvers at their waists. The other two wore black coats cut somewhere between a trench coat and a formal suit, with a faint Church style to them. At their waists he could see not only holsters for large revolvers, but also long steel swords that seemed out of place in this age.

The two people in black coats had one more eye-catching item at their belts: a consecrated lantern decorated with runes, clearly used for night patrols.

They seemed to be handing over their shift at the intersection. Duncan paused, then quickly understood.

They were constables under City Hall and Guardians under the Church.

Constables kept order in the city by day. Guardians protected the city-state's peace under the veil of night. Now the Sun was sinking. The time of day and night changing was almost here, the moment when secular power and holy power traded places.

This was one of the world's unique "sights".

The four of them seemed not to notice Duncan.

Duncan walked over calmly. He had hesitated for a moment, but soon reminded himself that he had a clear conscience.

A law-abiding citizen taking a walk before dark was not committing a crime.

One of the Church Guardians doing the handover finally noticed someone walking toward them. The tall young man raised his head, saw Duncan, and at once waved his hand and called out in warning: "citizen! It is getting dark. Go home quickly. It is not safe outside."

"Officers! I want to report something," Duncan said, picking up his pace. He walked over and spoke with great sincerity: "Just now I heard a lot of noise from that abandoned factory over there. Earlier I saw many shady types sneaking in and out…"

He paused here, then added: "I read in the newspaper before that we should actively report strange gatherings and odd noises around us…"

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Chapter 79: lamplight in the Shabby Alley

Far from the abandoned factory, deep in a shabby alley, a plain old little house suddenly lit up with an oil lamp.

In the flickering light, one could see the room's simple, worn furniture, the slightly moldy ceiling, the peeling, faded wallpaper, and, in the corner of the room, a black crack that slowly squirmed and shrank.

A terrifying-looking skeletal hound lay beside the crack, motionless like a dead dog drained of all strength. On the other end of a black iron chain, Shirley, in her black dress with white trim, carefully adjusted the oil lamp's wick, then came to the window to check the sky outside, still worried.

"…The World's Wound is out…" the girl breathed softly. "Good thing we got home before the veil of night fully fell. Otherwise we might have died in some stinking ditch like a dog."

The Abyssal Hound lying like a corpse on the floor nearby lifted its head at once. A harsh, cracking sound came from its throat: "Say what you want, but leave dogs out of it."

"You can still talk? I thought you lost half your life on that Abyssal Deep jump," Shirley said, turning to glance at Dog. "Can you tell me now? Why did we suddenly have to run, and using the most dangerous Abyssal Deep crossing at that? Didn't you say there were countless demons waiting in the Abyssal Deep, in the Deep Sea, to chew up your black bones?"

“No matter how many demons there are in the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea, I can still dodge them. I might not be able to beat them, but I can outrun them. But just now… if we hadn’t run, we might not have run at all,” the Abyssal Hound said, finally sounding as if it had caught its breath. It lifted its head a little to look at Shirley. “You should be glad I reacted fast and opened the crack the moment that scary fellow looked away. As long as his gaze was still on us, I couldn’t even open an escape path!”

Shirley frowned and slowly walked up to the Abyssal Hound: “So what was it, exactly? Why were you that scared? That man called ‘Duncan’… Dog, have you seen him before? Is he some big shot in the Church of Annihilation, or does he have some Abyssal demon standing behind him?”

The Abyssal Hound seemed to recall some extremely terrible feeling. All its bones clattered once, and then it lowered its voice and muttered: “I have never seen him. I do not know him.”

Shirley’s eyes went wide at once: “You got that scared of someone you’ve never even seen before?!”

“Even if I have never seen him before, as a Abyssal demon I can still ‘see’ shadows worse than death!” The Abyssal Hound suddenly raised its head. Its hollow, red eye sockets stared straight at Shirley. “Inside a human shell, he had a damned whirlpool of light and shadow that made even me feel mentally deranged with just one look. How could I not be afraid?!”

It paused, as if trying to find the right words to describe its feeling to Shirley, who was human. It thought for a long time before slowly speaking: “When he talked, I could hear ten thousand overlapping voices howling at the same time. When he cast his divine gaze, I could feel my entire fate, from birth to death, laid out flat on the ground for someone to view. Let me tell you, the last time I met something that scary was that time I saw the

‘Holy Lord’ from far away in the Abyssal Deep, in the Deep Sea. But the Holy Lord cannot move. Today we met someone who can walk and move.”

Dog’s frightened tone and stare—though his eyes were just two glowing holes—made Shirley’s skin crawl. Even so, she still muttered under her breath: “How come I did not feel anything back then… I even thought he seemed pretty nice…”

“That is why I sometimes envy you humans and your slow, dull senses. That screen of ignorance really is the greatest gift the world gave you. It lets you die with a smile in the middle of mad, twisted doom,” the Abyssal Hound said weakly, flopping back down. “Stay blind and clueless. The world will be a bit nicer that way. Poor little dogs like me are not so lucky. Every few days I get to see something that can scare a dog to death…”

“How in the world can there be a Abyssal demon as cowardly as you, damn it,” Shirley could not help giving Dog a sideways look. Then she seemed to think of something and said hesitantly, “But the way you put it, I feel like maybe we shouldn’t have run. If he really is some super powerful big shot, like you said, maybe we could latch onto him. Look, he was actually quite nice to us just now. He even asked us things. And he seemed to be at odds with those Sun bastards. Isn’t that a chance? I could act cute, play the spoiled girl a little. If he turned out to be a backer…”

Before the girl finished speaking, the black iron chain clattered. Dog, who had been lying there like a corpse a moment ago, suddenly jumped up: “Drop that crazy idea right now! Your level of insanity is already enough to open a Subspace channel!”

It paused, then kept warning her, still uneasy: “Listen. Never deal with those things that wear a human shell but are unspeakable inside. They are more cunning than pure demons and more vicious than real humans. Their calm talk with you is always only the appetizer to a feast. Do not be fooled

by how friendly he seemed just now. Do you really think that if you told him everything you know, he would let you walk away whole?”

It seemed the Abyssal Hound’s never-before-heard harsh tone had worked. Shirley looked a bit cowed. She finally gave up her bold idea, but still grumbled: “I know, I know. But Dog, you sound like an old nagging mother…”

The Abyssal Hound flopped down on the floor: “Of course I do. I raised you!”

Shirley snorted, then looked out the window at the sky. Seeing that the veil of night had already sunk low, she stepped toward the window.

The black iron chain went taut as the girl walked. The Abyssal Hound, who had wanted to lie and rest, was helplessly dragged along the floor. This huge, heavy Abyssal demon was pulled around in Shirley’s hands as if it weighed nothing. “What are you trying to do now? Can you not let me lie here for a while? We fought such a big battle today. I am exhausted…”

“I did most of the fighting, all right?” Shirley said, still looking outside without turning back. “I am checking the situation out there… It’s completely dark now. The street lamps have only just turned on.”

“This is the Slum Quarter, after all. The authority already does well enough by keeping these street lamps at the most basic level of warding. Do not expect them to light up before the dusk bell like in other districts,” Dog grumbled. He glanced back at the oil lamp on the old dining table. “Turn the lamp off later. Oil is expensive.”

Shirley pressed her lips together: “…We can put it out before we sleep. Otherwise it will be too dark in here.”

Dog’s stomach rumbled, but he said nothing.

Within the city-state, the city's administrators and builders strictly planned the position and number of "street lamps", the most basic warding devices. The gas lamps spread across the city could keep the whole district under protection after nightfall. Because of that, surface homes were safe whether they used electric lights or oil lamps. It was even safe to put out the lights inside after the street lamps were lit.

But even the most prosperous city had forgotten corners. In the depths of the Shantytown, which was even older and more run-down than the Lower City, gas lamps were far fewer than in other areas. They barely managed to keep day and night safe, and that kind of "just barely enough" state was clearly not enough to make people feel at ease.

So, in the Slum Quarter, oil lamps and tallow candles that burned with real flame were things every family needed.

If the street lamps were late by a while, the firelight at home could at least hold back the darkness after the Sun went down for a time.

Of course, there was another important reason many poor families used oil lamps and candles. They could not afford the relatively high cost of switching to electric power.

Electric lights were bright, clean, and safe. In the worry-free districts, they had long been the first choice for lighting in every home. But in this little house in the Shantytown…

The only thing that could still give Shirley and Dog a sense of safety was the wavering flame in that old lamp.

In the dim lamplight, the voice of the Abyssal Hound broke the silence: "… Are you still going out for a while longer these days?"

"Mm."

"Still going after those Sun bastards?"

“I am going to get information out of them.”

“Same thing, more or less… But from the looks of it, they do not seem to know very clearly what happened eleven years ago either. Look at today. Even they were asking the locals.”

“That was because today’s group just happened to all come from Lunsa. Next time we might get something.”

“Fine, as long as you are happy.”

“Just make my disguise a bit more reliable next time, Dog. Do not let it fall apart halfway through again.”

“I just hope we do not run into that scary man again. I suspect our aura leaked early today because there was such a strong ‘interference’ at the scene…”

“All right, all right. If you say so, then so it is…”

Chapter 80: Home Visit?

Before the last streak of sunset faded at the horizon, Duncan saw the familiar front of the antique shop.

The gas lamps along the street were already lit. Their faint yellow light shone on the sign above the door and the dusty gray walls. Warm light also glowed in the display windows on either side of the entrance. Clearly, Nina had already come home—she had turned on the lights on the first floor and was waiting for Duncan to return.

Strictly speaking, from Duncan's point of view he and Nina had only just met. Yet for some reason, when he saw the lights on downstairs, he felt a strange… guilt.

[Was this guilt because I had gone out and stayed away too long?]

Duncan stepped forward and pushed open the front door of the antique shop. The bell hanging above the entrance rang with a clear chime. A second later he heard hurried footsteps coming from the stairs.

A girl in a plain long dress ran down from upstairs like a gust of wind.

"Uncle Duncan!" Nina stopped on the stairs and looked at Duncan at the door with surprise and joy, and also a bit of disbelief in her eyes. "I thought today you were going to…"

"I took a walk in the city and didn't notice it was almost dark," Duncan shook his head. "Sorry. I actually meant to go to Crossroad District to pick you up after school, but something unexpected came up."

“You went to Crossroad District?” Nina looked at Duncan in surprise and confusion. Her eyes ran up and down him, as if checking whether Uncle had been drinking again outside, or was dull from medicine. “To… pick me up after school?”

Uncle Duncan was showing another side that was both strange and familiar, and Nina once again had no idea how she should react.

“I was just a bit curious about how you’re doing at school now,” Duncan said casually. “Anyway, let’s not talk about that. From now on you don’t need to worry about me going out to drink or hanging around with my ‘friends’. If I come back late, it will be because I had proper business to take care of. All right?”

Nina stared blankly as Uncle Duncan came in and closed the door. Seeing how steady his steps were and how full of energy he looked, she nodded without thinking.

“It’s getting late,” Duncan said as he walked toward the stairs to the second floor, speaking to Nina who stood by the stairway. “Have you eaten?”

“Not… yet,” Nina answered, still not used to how Uncle had changed, so her voice sounded a little hesitant. “When I came back and saw you weren’t home, I didn’t know if you were coming back tonight, so… I didn’t cook. But I bought some bread. I was planning to…”

“Just eating bread isn’t nutritious enough. Come on, there’s something good in the kitchen,” Duncan was about to step onto the stairs. He turned back and smiled at Nina. “I’m cooking today.”

Uncle was going to cook?!

Nina felt as if she had just heard some sort of wild tale, but before she could ask anything, she saw Uncle Duncan already striding upstairs. She had no choice but to hurry after him. At the same time, her gaze fell on AI, who

was perched steadily on Duncan's shoulder, and she was startled: "Uncle, has this pigeon been with you the whole time?"

"Yeah. It's quite clingy," Duncan said offhandedly. "Oh, right, I gave it a name. It's called AI."

"AI? For a pigeon… that's such a strange name…" Nina scratched her hair. She had already followed him up to the second floor and watched Uncle Duncan actually head for the kitchen. At last she couldn't hold back and asked: "Did you buy anything?"

"It's just a piece of dried salted fish," Duncan said. He found the salted fish he had stored away in a kitchen cabinet, lifted the hard thing, and waved it at Nina with a rather proud look. "It doesn't look like much, but it makes a very good soup."

"Fish?!" Nina's eyes opened wide in surprise. "What day is it today? Fish is so expensive, normally we would never… huh?"

She finally saw the dried fish clearly. The plain-looking thing left the girl very confused. She blinked at it for a long time. "What kind of fish is that? I've never seen it before."

Duncan had known Nina would react like this.

Of course, the residents of the city-state had seen fish before. The Boundless Sea was dangerous, and in the Deep Sea there were things called "Spawn" that threatened human safety. But not every sea area was as strange and extreme as the Deep Sea. Under the protection of the Gods and the city-state's own defenses, the waters close to the city, the Shallow Sea, and a few blessed routes were relatively safer. These regions provided precious resources for the city-state's civilization.

People gathered seafood and minerals from the Nearshore Waters, and hunted whales and other fish of great industrial value along the routes under

the Gods' protection. These things kept the city-states alive and supported their industrial growth.

With all that, the job of "fisherman" naturally existed.

But the seas of this world were nothing like those of Earth. Even the "safe" waters were only safe compared to the Deep Sea. So in this world, even nearshore fishing was something extremely specialized and dangerous, and it called for extraordinary knowledge and combat skills.

To people living in the city-states, fish was a familiar yet expensive ingredient.

Even though the sea was right beside them, and there were countless fish in it.

Nina had not eaten fish for many years. Even before her uncle fell ill, a commoner like her had very few chances to see fish served on the table.

Ordinary fish were already that rare, let alone a gift from the Deep Sea.

Duncan even suspected that this Deep Sea fish he had caught on the Vanished was appearing in the city-state of Pland for the first time. Not to mention a commoner young lady like Nina—probably even the city-state's Governor and the senior priests of the Church had never tasted anything like it.

Nina was in for a treat today.

"Don't worry about what kind it is. Just wait and eat." Duncan knew there were some things he could not explain clearly, so he simply did not try. He turned back into the kitchen and began to prepare dinner.

The strange fish was not small. Even after it had been dried, it was still quite large, and there was no way they could finish it in one pot of soup. So he cut the salted fish into two pieces and decided to use the head section

first. The rest he could thread with a rope and hang back in the cupboard to dry even more. It might taste better that way.

Uncle really did start cooking.

Watching his familiar figure busy in the kitchen, Nina felt as if she were dreaming.

She did not actually care at all what was going on with that strange fish Uncle had brought out. She was not even truly concerned about tonight's dinner.

Compared to those small details, the changes in Uncle were far stranger, and far more worth paying attention to.

The sound of knife on chopping board rang out. The gas stove hissed, and the broth in the pot bubbled with a soft gurgle.

Nina felt a little dazed. How many years had it been since she had seen a scene like this?

A trace of hesitation appeared on her face. After a moment, as if suddenly making up her mind, she stood at the kitchen door and spoke to the busy back inside: "Uncle, tomorrow… Mr. Morris is coming for a home visit."

"A home visit?" Duncan, busy cooking, froze for a moment when he heard this. "Mr. Morris… your history teacher?"

Nina nodded. "Yes."

"Teachers at that school actually do home visits?" Duncan dropped the prepared pieces of fish into the pot, then put the knife into the sink and turned back to glance at Nina in surprise. "I thought that was a 'special feature' only the schools up in the Upper City had."

"The school… doesn't really have that rule," Nina said carefully, watching Duncan's expression. "But Old Mr. Morris is a bit special. He… cares a lot

about his students.”

For a moment, Duncan said nothing.

This was a bit beyond what he had expected.

He had never thought that, while he was moving around the city-state as “Captain Duncan”, he would suddenly have to deal with something like this!

He had thought about having to deal with the Church, thought about dealing with the constables, even the City Navy and the Military Police Corps. Whether he wanted it or not, all his plans were filled with spirit flame, blades, and the Vanished’s more than a hundred broadside cannons.

But he had never planned for an old man who taught history at a public school to appear in them.

[Why is the Mortal Realm always so full of surprises?]

“Uncle?” Nina grew a bit worried when she saw Duncan stay silent for so long. “You don’t want to, right? I can tell Old Mr. Morris… In fact, I already told him today. I told him your health wasn’t good, so you couldn’t really handle a home visit this time. He didn’t say anything then…”

Seeing Nina’s slightly nervous reaction, Duncan’s thoughts started to turn.

It seemed that Old Mr. Morris had not asked for a home visit just this once.

[So how many times has Nina turned him down with the same excuse?]

“…He teaches history, right?” Duncan suddenly asked again.

Nina didn’t know why her uncle was asking this again, but she still nodded. “Yes.”

“Good. I’ve been wanting to talk to a professional in the field of history,” Duncan said with a smile. “When is he coming tomorrow?”

Chapter 81: Memory Deviation

A scholar who for some unknown reason had gone to a commoners' school to teach history, a teacher well versed in ancient history who also seemed to get along quite well with Nina—his coming was an unexpected situation for Duncan, but also an opportunity.

Old Mr. Morris's learning in his field would surely help Duncan solve many questions. And if he could build a good relationship with such a professional, it might bring unexpected convenience in the future—a well-regarded old scholar was bound to have some connections in the city-state.

Nina did not know why her Uncle Duncan had suddenly agreed to the home visit. She did not think too deeply about it; she only felt especially happy.

In that hazy moment she even had an illusion—as if her life was really moving in a better direction, slowly… going back to how it had been in the past.

Outside the window, the veil of night deepened. The pale, cold light of the World's Wound shone on the windowsill of the antique shop's second floor. Under the quiet night, the whole city slowly grew still.

In this world filled with strange and eerie things, most people had no such thing as nightlife.

"Come eat," Duncan called to his dazed "niece" by the window. He set the pot of fish soup on the table, along with the bread Nina had bought that afternoon and the onion rings he had just fried on a whim. In his eyes this dinner was not really rich, but considering how special the "fish" was, this

meal might even count as a feast in a place like the Lower City. “You still have to get up early for school tomorrow.”

“Oh, all right, Uncle Duncan.”

Nina answered and obediently came to the table. The aroma of the fish soup had already spread. She sniffed in surprise and looked at Duncan in disbelief. “It smells so good… Uncle, when did your cooking get this good?”

“You call this good cooking?” Duncan could not help laughing. He thought that his cooking skills were probably only a little better than Alice’s, and yet someone was actually praising him. “Was I really that bad before?”

“‘Bad’ isn’t enough to describe it. You used to cook by the standard of ‘as long as it doesn’t kill you’. And even though your cooking was awful, you always wanted to ambitiously try new dishes, and every time you dragged me along to be your test subject…” Nina chattered on and on as she recalled the old days, actually a bit animated. “Once you made something so disgusting that even you couldn’t eat it. You had to throw it into the trash, then you dragged me to the family restaurant on the next street for lunch. When we came back, we saw the neighbor’s dog squatting by the trash can at the door, throwing up all over the place. After that, whenever the dog saw you, it walked around you in a big circle…”

As Nina spoke, her voice slowly faded.

“Forget it. That was years ago, and you never liked me bringing it up…”

Duncan stayed silent.

In the memories left in this body, there was not the slightest trace of what Nina was recalling. These were almost the only good memories she had with her uncle, yet they had all vanished completely with the wayward man’s last breath.

Nina silently broke apart the dry, hard bread and used the rich soup to soften it bit by bit.

Duncan suddenly reached out and ruffled the child's hair.

Nina looked up in surprise. "Uncle?"

"Your uncle's new recipe experiment was a success," Duncan said with a perfectly serious face.

Nina stared at Duncan in a daze. Her expression changed several times as who knew how many thoughts circled in her mind. In the end, all those expressions turned into a smile she could not hold back. "Uncle, you look so funny when you act all serious!"

"Don't make fun of your lord," Duncan glanced at Nina, then as if suddenly remembering something, he added casually, "Oh, right. I'm planning to sort the shop out properly over the next while. If you see anything strange and unfamiliar on the first floor, don't touch it."

He was preparing for the coming shuttling between two places and the flow of "supplies" back and forth.

As AI's abilities were developed, he would have to teleport cargo back and forth between the Vanished and the antique shop more and more often. It would be hard to hide all of that from Nina's eyes—so it was better to give her a little warning ahead of time.

Nina did not doubt him at all and quickly nodded. Duncan then went on: "Also, I'm thinking of adding another pair of hands at the shop. That way, if I go out during the day, someone can stay and look after the place. Of course, it's only an early plan, it might not work out. I just wanted to tell you in advance so you won't feel strange if you suddenly see a stranger in the shop one day."

This time, he was laying the groundwork for Alice's arrival—just laying the groundwork, for now.

Bringing that doll girl into the city-state still involved many problems. Teleporting her here was only the least of them. He also had to think about how to keep Alice's true nature as a "doll" from being discovered. Alice looked almost no different from a real person. As long as she wore long gloves to hide the joints of her hands, there would be no big problem. At most she would need a veil to cover that face of hers, which was even more delicate than a living girl's. Those were all small issues. The real problem… was that thing's head.

He was bringing Alice over to help him. He could not have that one running around in front of people, clutching her head and bolting away all day.

Nina, on the other hand, looked at Duncan in surprise. "Uncle, you're actually going to hire a shop assistant? That's a big deal… Do you already have someone in mind? What kind of person is it?"

Duncan thought for a moment and carefully filtered out a whole string of less-than-flattering adjectives from his mind. Then he put on a straight face. "I have an initial candidate. She's a… hardworking young lady."

He considered it carefully. "Hardworking" seemed to be the only praise that still fit Alice.

Then he saw Nina's expression suddenly turn subtle.

The young lady looked her uncle up and down several times and finally could not help herself. "A young lady? Uncle, don't tell me you…"

Duncan had seen enough of the world to know what she was thinking the instant he saw her face. He knocked his fingers on the table at once. "Eat your food properly! What are you imagining!"

Nina instantly tried to hold back her laughter, making little snorting sounds as she lowered her head and kept eating. After tasting a piece of fish, she opened her eyes wide in surprise again. “It’s really good!”

Duncan laughed and tore off a bit of bread, tossing it to the pigeon pacing nearby. “Then eat more. There’s plenty left in the kitchen.”

On the small second floor of the antique shop, Nina and her Uncle Duncan finished this simple yet long-lost kind of dinner.

After dinner, once everything was cleaned up, Duncan called out to Nina just as she was about to go back to her room to rest.

There were some things he wanted to confirm.

“Nina,” he said, looking at the girl who had just come out of the kitchen with the dishes. “I have something I want to ask you.”

“Huh?” Nina was a little curious. “What is it?”

“Do you still remember… things from when you were little?” Duncan chose his words carefully as he spoke, while recalling the information he had heard at that cultist gathering. “When you were six.”

Nina frowned. She did not know why her uncle had suddenly brought up something from eleven years ago, but she still began to think.

It had been eleven years, and she had only been six back then, so when she thought back on it now, she did not actually feel much sadness.

“I was still very young then, so there are many things I can’t remember clearly. I only remember that day was very chaotic… there were panicked adults everywhere. Some people said a factory near Crossroad District had a leak. Some said there was mass hysteria on Lower Third Street. Some even said something had happened in the Upper City… A lot of it I didn’t

understand at the time. I only matched the pieces later, when I heard the adults talking about it again."

Duncan thought for a moment and looked into Nina's eyes. "Then do you remember a big fire? I carried you out of the fire that time. Your parents… they were in that fire…"

He was only testing the waters, but to his surprise Nina's eyes suddenly went wide. "The fire? Uncle, you really remember that there was a big fire back then?!"

"…Of course I remember," Duncan said. Her reaction told him at once that something about it was wrong. "Is there something wrong with the fire I remember?"

"I also remember there was a fire. A huge, huge fire," Nina said quickly, a little excited. "But later, when I told the adults around me about it, not a single one of them remembered. They all said I'd been scared silly, that there hadn't been any fire at all… When I got older, I even went to look for the newspapers from back then on purpose…"

She stopped there and slowly shook her head, a strange look on her face. "But even in the newspapers there was no mention of any big fire… All the records only said that a factory had leaked chemicals, and that the chemicals had caused mass hallucinations…"

Chapter 82: The Fire That Existed Only in Dreams

Nina went back to her room to sleep.

In this world, most people went to bed early and got up early. After the Sun faded, the hours were dangerous. The faint glow of the World's Wound pushed the whole world's distortion to its peak. Even in cities, where lights offered some protection, people still had to face the veil of night with great care.

People could not go out and gather, and there were not many ways to have fun. Reading at night was not as dangerous as reading at sea, but it still easily led to mental fatigue, hallucinations of sound and sight, and sometimes even drew unnecessary attention from the veil of night. So, all in all, the safest thing was to sleep early and wait for the Sun to rise the next day.

But Duncan did not feel sleepy at all.

He put out the lights in the room and stood by the window in just his shirt. He casually enjoyed the view of Pland's night under the veil of night while he thought back to his talk with Nina after dinner.

Nina remembered a great fire. The leftover memories in this body also held such a fire. In that fire, "he" carried a girl who was only six out of a collapsing, burning building. Far off on the streets, crowds ran wild through thick fog.

However, only the two of them remembered that fire. Nina had gone to other lords to talk about it, but they treated it as confused memories from a little child scared out of her wits. The newspapers from eleven years ago clearly recorded the “truth”: at the border between Pland’s Lower City and Crossroad District, there had only been a factory leak that caused mass hallucinations. There was no record of any fire.

Duncan frowned a little. The other suspicious point lay in “himself.”

According to Nina, “Uncle Duncan” also did not remember this fire. All along, she had been the only one who remembered. When she was little, she had even told Uncle Duncan about the fire—though back then he should still have been “Ron”—and Uncle Duncan had been one of the lords who thought she had only been scared silly and misremembered everything.

But now, scenes of the fire had appeared in Duncan’s memory. They were remnants of this body’s original master, buried in the deepest part of the mind.

Where had the problem started? Why, in Nina’s memory, had her Uncle never remembered the fire, yet Duncan had found matching images in this body’s deepest memories? Had Nina’s Uncle been lying all along? Or had the memory been sealed away until a ghost captain took over this body and the memories in the deep layers finally rose to the surface?

Duncan tapped the window frame with his fingers without thinking as he quietly sorted the timeline in his mind.

He pieced together what he had learned from those Suntists:

Eleven years ago, a fragment of the Sun first appeared within the city-state of Pland. The supernatural phenomena caused by that fragment might have covered a very large area.

That same year, Nina became an orphan. In both her memories and Duncan's, there had been a great fire in the Lower City. But aside from the two of them, no one remembered such a fire, and there was no evidence at all that it had ever happened.

After that, the fragment of the Sun lay dormant in the city-state and showed no further activity. The only record left from that year's incident was the "Crossroad District factory leak."

For several years, Nina and her only remaining relative relied on each other to survive.

Four years ago, the Suntists God in Pland tried to awaken the sleeping fragment of the Sun ahead of time. They held a dangerous sacrificial ritual, but the ritual failed before it could be completed. A newly promoted apprentice Inquisitor, Vanna, led a team and smashed it. The Cult's power suffered a heavy blow. After a large, sweeping purge, the Sun God's Church was driven out of the city-state.

But even though that ritual had not reached its final step, the cultists' attempt to "awaken" it might still have had some effect. After that, the fragment of the Sun slowly began to stir from its slumber.

Around the same time, the "Uncle" who lived with Nina fell ill with a strange sickness. The pain slowly dragged him down. In the end, he accepted the temptation of the Suntists still hiding in the city and became one of the Cult's lackeys.

Not long ago, news that the fragment of the Sun was active again began to draw Suntists back to this city. The cultists who had lain low for four years once more held a sacrificial ritual. What happened after that… was Duncan's intervention.

Many things along this timeline seemed faintly linked, yet they all lacked key evidence.

The most suspicious part was still eleven years ago. What kind of supernatural manifestations had the fragment of the Sun really triggered back then? Had that great fire truly existed or not?

Had the city-state's authority erased the truth of the incident and wiped away all traces of the fire? Had they announced it as a factory leak that caused mass hallucinations, just to keep order?

But that still could not explain why so many people had no memory of the fire at all—unless the authority had gone to great trouble to reshape the memories of everyone involved.

There was another point. In this world, Anomalies and Visions were openly known to the public. Even small children knew about the existence and danger of supernatural things. The authority clearly knew this and had always ruled the city by "warning people early so that citizens knew how to protect themselves." If it had really only been a fire caused by an supernatural power… why would they have to hide it?

Unless… there had been an even bigger problem behind that fire, something so dangerous that even letting the news spread would have sent that danger into a runaway state.

Duncan suddenly frowned.

Or there was another possibility.

supernatural phenomena were strange by nature. Many times, the harm they caused was not limited to the physical world. They could twist human perception and even twist evidence already written on paper. What if people's memories and understanding of that incident, and even the records

kept by the city-state's authority and the Church, had all been corrupted by the fragment of the Sun?

Duncan felt that his own imagination was going too far. As a half-trained "beginner" in the field of Anomalies and Visions, his thoughts were maybe running wild. But once this idea appeared, he could not stop thinking about it.

People's memories, the authority's records, even the words written in black ink on white paper in old files from ten years ago—all of it could be twisted and replaced. In the past he might not have believed such a thing, but now he believed it more than anyone.

Because the place he stood in was now called "Duncan Antique Shop."

Everyone here knew their old neighbor, Mr. Duncan, who ran the antique shop.

Duncan let out a soft breath. He lowered his head and looked through the second-floor window at the street lit by gas lamps.

Only one question remained.

No matter whether the great fire eleven years ago had really happened or not, no matter whether the fragment of the Sun had corrupted the memories of those involved and the city's records, one point was crucial:

Why did Nina remember that fire.

…

In the Upper City, inside a mansion that belonged to the Governor.

Vanna woke from a nightmare.

But this time, the nightmare was no longer about the Black Sun, nor did it point toward that ship, the Vanished, which had returned from Subspace.

She had simply dreamed about her childhood.

On that night filled with fog, smoke, blood, and maddened crowds, twelve-year-old Vanna had been carried on her Uncle's back as they fled from a gang of rioters.

In the dream, she seemed to return to how helpless and fragile she had been back then. The martial skills she was so proud of, and her powerful divine magic, were gone. All she could do was run in panic as madmen and shadows chased them. She and her Uncle climbed over the pipes and valves above a factory. In the thick smoke and heat, she looked down at the city in terror and saw endless flames rising everywhere, covering the whole district as far as she could see…

The young Inquisitor, still in her nightgown, sat on the bed and took a deep breath as she looked at the sky outside the window. The pale light of the World's Wound still hung high in the heavens, and the chronometer clock by the window showed that it was only just past midnight.

She felt as if she had been trapped in the nightmare for a century.

Vanna got up and turned up the electric lamp. She walked to the dressing table and looked at herself in the mirror. She softly spoke the name of the Storm Goddess. Only after she felt her heart calm did she sigh and murmur to herself, as if to comfort herself: "At least I won't be dreaming about that ship anymore…"

As soon as she finished speaking, she suddenly heard footsteps in the hallway outside her room. Then came a knock on the door: "Vanna? Vanna, did you have another nightmare?"

It was her Uncle's voice—the most respected Governor of this city-state.

"I'm fine." Vanna steadied herself, straightened her clothes, and went to open the door.

Dante Wayne stood at the door. The gray-haired, gray-eyed middle-aged man, not very broad in build, had clearly just woken up too. He had thrown on a coat, and when the door opened he looked at his niece with concern.

He had lost one eye in an old incident, and now he wore an eye made of ruby. Delicate golden lines could be seen inside that eye, and around it the socket still carried the fierce scars left eleven years ago. They made his face look frightening.

But Vanna had long since gotten used to it. She knew that her Uncle was actually a gentle and fair man.

“I had a nightmare,” she said, rubbing her eyes with a helpless tone. “I didn’t think it would wake you.”

“It’s nothing. At my age, I sleep lightly anyway,” Dante said as he looked at Vanna with concern. “You dreamed about your childhood again?”

“Yes. I dreamed of that time again.”

Chapter 83: Ghosts Also Entangled with the Mortal Realm

Her Uncle brought some calming herbal liquor. The herbs and the alcohol together slowly eased Vanna's restless mood. She opened the door to the balcony, stepped out into the wind, and looked toward the distant Cathedral.

Dante's voice came from behind her: "Every time you come back to stay, you have these nightmares, and they always take you back to your childhood."

"…For an Inquisitor, this is a weakness I shouldn't have," Vanna said in a low voice. She was more than a head taller than her Uncle, but in front of the elder who had raised her, she never minded showing her true feelings. "It troubles me."

"…Have you talked to Heidi?"

"She recommended four kinds of brain surgery and two kinds of nerve-piercing therapy," Vanna sighed. "Considering our years of friendship, I didn't hit her."

"…That sounds like her. She doesn't deal with normal people much," Dante said, shaking his head. "I didn't think that after all these years, you would still be trapped by that night's nightmare."

"I always thought I had already moved past it," Vanna said, rubbing her brow. "Maybe it really has something to do with this big house. Every time I come back here, I dream of those scenes again… Maybe I should perform

another exorcism ritual for this place. Otherwise I keep feeling that the shadows of that disaster are still sealed inside these walls…”

Uncle Dante thought about it for a moment. He did not object, but asked thoughtfully: “Did you see that fire in your nightmare again this time?”

Vanna nodded. “Yes. There was fire everywhere. You carried me out of the fire. I remember clearly that we fled along the factory pipes to escape the district. Nearby, a burning building was slowly collapsing in the flames…”

She stopped there and looked at her Uncle. “…You don’t remember any fire, do you?”

“It’s not just me. No one remembers it,” the city-state’s Governor said, slowly shaking his head with a serious expression. “I only remember the leaking gas pipes and those crazed cultists… There were many people involved that night, but it seems only you saw a sea of roaring flames.”

Vanna did not speak for a long time. She stayed silent and thought for who knew how long before she suddenly spoke softly: “Aside from the ‘fire’ part, your memories and mine match… Back then I didn’t understand anything, but now I know that this must be the work of some supernatural power. So many years have passed, and I have even advanced to become a Saint, yet this influence still has not faded.”

“That means either the source of this influence has a very high rank and burned an everlasting mark into your soul, or the source itself did not vanish when the incident ended. Instead, it has stayed hidden somewhere in the city-state. I have been investigating this for years, but sadly, there has been no progress.”

Dante’s voice carried a hint of apology at the end. He was not only sorry that he could not ease his niece’s pain, but also regretful that, as the city-state’s Governor, he had still not been able to solve an old case.

The “Great Chaos” eleven years ago had left scars that ran too deep.

Vanna knew that this matter was not only a knot in her own heart. It had also weighed on her Uncle all this time. But she was not good at comforting others. After thinking for a long time, all she could do was change the subject: “I remember we arrested a lot of cultists back then. From the later reports, that incident was even bigger than the ‘Black Sun’ incident four years ago.”

“Yes. We arrested thousands. There were so many that I even wondered how that many cultists could hide in just one city-state, Pland,” Dante sighed. “And it wasn’t just one sect… There were Suntists who followed the Black Sun, Annihilators who worshiped the Abyssal Lord, and even Enders who worshiped Subspace itself… All those maggots from the sewers crawled out that night and ran around wrecking everything in a frenzy.”

Vanna looked at Dante. “But according to the later interrogations, among the thousands of saboteurs the authority caught, not one could be called a ‘mastermind.’ Not a single one knew why the chaos had started that night. It was less like those cultists had planned to cause trouble together and more like the madness buried deep in their minds had all exploded at the same time. They had fallen into a collective runaway state.”

Dante did not speak for a moment. He thought quietly, then suddenly looked into Vanna’s eyes: “Your nerves aren’t just because of the nightmare, are they? You brought up all this so suddenly. Does it have something to do with the unrest in the city-state lately?”

Vanna did not avoid the question. “It does have something to do with it. Suntists are gathering toward the city-state. They are looking for an Anomaly called the fragment of the Sun. At almost the same time, the Vanished has reappeared in the Mortal Realm, and its ‘course’ seems to

point faintly toward Pland. We still don’t know if these two things are really connected, but this sense of turbulence… it keeps reminding me of the chaos eleven years ago.”

“…I have already ordered all the Harbors to strictly inspect everyone coming and going, and I have spoken with the Governors of other city-states. Quite a few Suntists were dragged off ships. We have basically cut off their way into the city-state. As for the ones who are already inside Pland… that will mostly depend on the Church. Guardians are the professionals when it comes to hunting down and locking onto supernatural crimes.”

When he said this, the middle-aged Governor suddenly stopped. He seemed to weigh whether he should bring something up now. After a moment of hesitation, he still made up his mind. “As for the Vanished, I can’t do much in the supernatural field. But in the secular world, I have an idea.”

“In the secular world?” Vanna frowned. She was just about to say how that ghost ship, the Vanished, could have anything to do with the “secular” side, when she suddenly remembered a certain rumor. “Wait, you mean…”

“The captain of the pioneer exploration ship, the Radiant Star, Lucretia Abnomar, and the pirate lord in the Northern Seas, Tyrian Abnomar, captain of the Sea Mist,” Dante said slowly. “It’s true that the Vanished is a ghost ship beyond the Mortal Realm’s understanding. But as long as it once belonged to the Mortal Realm, the Mortal Realm still holds the ‘anchor points’ of its existence… I wonder how Captain Duncan’s two children will react to their ‘father’ returning to the world again.”

Vanna’s eyes slowly widened. She was used to dealing with enemies in simple, direct ways and had never thought about the Vanished from this angle. But soon she frowned. “I’ve heard that those two hardly deal with any city-state powers at all… On the Boundless Sea, they each rule their

own territories and keep distant, even tense relations with all the city-states."

"That's normal. After all, they are the children of that ghost captain, and the Radiant Star and the Sea Mist were once the two escort ships of the Vanished. Even though they parted ways more than a hundred years ago, in the eyes of most city-states, anyone who had anything to do with that ghost captain meant the curse and danger. It's not so much that they keep their distance from the city-states as it is that the city-states have been avoiding them."

Vanna looked at her Uncle with a frown. "So you're counting on them to help Pland fight their own father?"

"It's only an idea, but it's worth a try," Dante said, surprisingly serious. "After all, we all know that the Radiant Star and the Sea Mist parted ways with the Vanished more than a century ago. Lucretia and Tyrian had already broken with their father before the Viseran Thirteen Isles incident. And there were even rumors, more than half a century ago, that some Deep-Sea Captains personally saw the Sea Mist fighting the phantom of the Vanished in the Northern Seas. At that time, the Vanished had already become a legendary ghost ship. That might show those two captains' attitude when it comes to facing their own 'father.'"

"More than half a century ago… At that time, the Sea Mist was still the main flagship under the Frostholm Queen's command. Captain Tyrian might have only been protecting the city-state under orders," Vanna said slowly as she thought. "But you're right. At least it proves that the Sea Mist really does have a record of fighting the Vanished."

But she still had doubts. After a few seconds of thought, she spoke them aloud: "What if the Radiant Star and the Sea Mist ignore Pland?"

“That’s why this is only a try,” Dante said quietly. “I’ll spread the word and find ways to get news of the Vanished’s return and its course toward Pland onto those two captains’ desks. That’s all I’ll do. How they react after that will be up to them.”

Chapter 84: Captain Duncan's Children

Even a ghost had once been a member of the Mortal Realm. No matter how terrifying the Vanished that had fallen into Subspace a century ago were now, they were still ships forged by artificers of the Mortal Realm. Just like Captain Duncan: before he became one of the shadows of Subspace, Duncan had also been a human.

For ordinary seafarers, everything connected to the Vanished was inevitably shrouded in a veil of "the curse" and strangeness. That terrifying ghost captain seemed like a creature born straight out of Subspace. No one would wonder whether a calamity that roamed the Boundless Sea had personal joys or sorrows, or any human relationships at all. In many people's minds, "Captain Duncan" was almost like a symbolic natural phenomenon—he simply existed, with no need to trace where he came from.

Fear built high walls in mortals' hearts, making them instinctively avoid thinking about what details lay beyond those walls.

But Vanna, an Inquisitor who specialized in facing this kind of fear, knew how to pick out what was real from a tangle of legends, exaggerations, and ravings.

That terrifying captain of the Vanished… when he had still been human, before the Viseran Thirteen Isles incident, he had also had close friends and family members. Under his command had been loyal sailors and adjutants.

He had needed to go to the harbor to maintain and resupply his ship, and to deal with the authority of the city-states.

He could not have been born a moving calamity.

Captain Duncan had a pair of children: his elder son, Tyrian Abnomar, and his daughter, Lucretia Abnomar—and they were still alive in this world.

It was said that some power of the curse had extended their lifespans, allowing these two captains to wander the world, immortal like their terrifying father.

Each of the two captains commanded a powerful ship and lingered for long years on the edge of the civilized world. Their relations with all the city-states were cold and faintly hostile. Many people could not even imagine that Captain Duncan still had a pair of children active in the world. Only a small number of people who knew history and kept their reason understood their story.

On the other hand, though they stayed distant from all city-states, these two captains at least still stood on the side of humans—the terrifying curse of the Vanished had not driven them to follow in Captain Duncan’s footsteps.

Lady Lucretia Abnomar’s ship, the Radiant Star, was a powerful vanguard exploration vessel. This lady was passionate about probing the limits of the world. It was said she had once reached the very edge of the Known World and there witnessed marvels beyond ordinary imagination.

No one knew what she searched for at the World’s Edge, but on rare occasions she would send envoys to visit the explorer associations of certain city-states and share some of the knowledge she had discovered along her routes. This faint, benevolent contact was proof that she still stood on the side of humans.

It was said that the explorer association of the Cold Harbor city-state had even awarded this mysterious lady an Honorary Member medal, though no one knew whether she had accepted that “honor”…

Tyrian Abnomar was a being even “closer” to the human world than his younger sister, yet he was more dangerous. More than half a century ago, he had served the Frostholm city-state in the Northern Seas. Now he was the most powerful pirate captain in the Frost Sea region.

This moody captain controlled nearly half of the main routes of the Frost Sea. His flagship was the Sea Mist, and more than a dozen warships fought under his command. In truth he had already become a semi-official power on the Frost Sea, alongside Cold Harbor and Frostholm. The islands he occupied had developed enough to stand on equal footing with a city-state, far beyond the concept of a mere “pirate band.”

As for how Captain Tyrian had transformed from a general under the Queen of Frostholm into a pirate leader, people told many different stories—

Some said that he had been the mastermind behind the Frostholm rebellion half a century ago, the one who personally sent the Frostholm Queen to the guillotine. After that, he had plundered the city-state’s wealth and used it to build his powerful pirate fleet.

Another version was the complete opposite. A few scholars believed that Tyrian Abnomar had fought for the Queen of Frostholm until the very last moment of the rebellion. He had eventually become a pirate and repeatedly attacked ships traveling between Frostholm and Cold Harbor because he had been left disheartened, driven by an obsession with avenging the Queen.

Vanna did not know how much truth or falsehood lay in all these tangled rumors. Considering the characters of those two captains, they probably had no interest in explaining themselves to the world either. But one thing was

certain: the return of the Vanished to the world was absolutely something they would have to pay attention to, guard against, and even prepare to meet with all their strength.

After all, these siblings had betrayed the Vanished with their own ships more than a century ago—and now their furious father had returned from Subspace.

Of course, just as Dante Wayne had said, this was only a spare card. It would be good if it could be played, but they could not place all their hopes on it.

What they could truly rely on was still their own strength.

…

When the bell tower of the Cathedral in the district chimed and the special rhythm of the steam whistle broke the night's silence, the city-state that had lain quiet all night slowly woke.

sunlight spread slowly along the distant rows of buildings. In the light, the "World's Wound" in the sky grew faint and faded away. The sounds of carts, horses, and pedestrians drifted up from the streets. The city surrounded by the Boundless Sea had passed through another veil of night and now welcomed the sunrise in peace.

Nina had gotten up early to make breakfast. The smell of mushroom sauce and toasted bread helped Duncan shake off the drowsiness of this human body in the morning. Listening to the bicycle bells ringing from the street outside, he suddenly said: "Do you want a bicycle?"

"A bicycle?" Nina froze for a moment, then waved her hand. "That's really expensive… And I don't really need one."

"It would make it easier for you to get to school," Duncan said. "You don't need to worry about the money. I'll figure something out."

He had already thought it over carefully. Although this antique shop did not look like much, judging from the stock piling up and rotating in the warehouse and the cash kept in the store, it ought to have steady sales in ordinary times. It was definitely more than enough to support two people.

Nina's current state of poverty was completely because her original uncle had donated more than half of the family property to a Cult. Most of what remained had been squandered on strong liquor, gambling dens, and drugs.

Now that degenerate life had ended. With those enormous, wasteful expenses cut off, he did not need to do anything special. As long as he kept the shop's business running normally, he could give Nina a life a little better than before.

Of course, he did not actually know how to run a shop, and the supply channels he knew of in his memories were a bit vague. But… that was something he could slowly get used to.

The most important thing was to let Nina truly feel at ease and get used to the change that her "uncle" had become reliable again.

Nina lowered her head and took small bites of the slightly stale bread. After a while she still repeated: "It's really expensive…"

Duncan opened his mouth and was just about to say something when he suddenly heard knocking from downstairs.

"This early… someone came before we even opened?" Nina paused when she heard the knocking, muttering under her breath. Then she stood up and walked out. "I'll go down and see!"

The girl ran downstairs in a hurry. Duncan casually broke off a piece of bread and tossed it to the pigeon pacing on the table: "Tell me… besides keeping the shop open, is there any faster way to make money? How about you start a logistics company?"

The pigeon immediately hopped two steps to the side and flapped its wings in outrage: “You really came just to make fun of me.”

Then it started to ramble on. “Then Jade flew into a rage and swung up the Serpent Halberd…” “Elder Tang raised both fists, beating Kieran until he spun like a top…” “When they finally looked up, a blood bar appeared above Tathagata’s head, filling the whole screen, and the three brothers broke out in a cold sweat”…

Duncan was completely stunned: “…”

He could understand that the pigeon could not speak when Nina was around and had been holding it in, but he could not understand what had happened to the bird’s brain after holding back that long—what kind of mess was in its vocabulary?!

But before he could open his mouth to speak to the pigeon, Nina’s voice suddenly came from downstairs. She sounded rather nervous: “Uncle Duncan! There… there are two constables here to see you…”

“Constables?” Two constables coming to look for him so early?

Duncan froze for a moment, then immediately ordered the pigeon to stay in the room. He got up and hurried downstairs.

As soon as he reached the first floor, he saw Nina looking back nervously toward the stairs, and the two constables in deep blue uniforms standing at the door of the antique shop.

Chapter 85: Reward

Duncan steadied himself and walked toward the two constables at the door.

His conscience was perfectly clear. He had not caused any damage or clashed with the authority. Captain Duncan's name might be infamous out on the Boundless Sea, but what did that roaming calamity have to do with him, an honest and proper antique shopkeeper?

Come to think of it, the most suspicious thing he had done was attend a cultist gathering—and afterward he had even gone out of his way to report it!

Wait… report?

Duncan suddenly remembered and immediately had a vague guess about why the two constables had come. His steps forward became much more confident. Nina, however, clearly did not share that calm. When she saw her uncle coming downstairs, she hurried over to meet him. Keeping her voice low where the two constables could not hear, she whispered urgently: "Uncle, when the two constables ask questions later, you have to answer honestly…"

Duncan stumbled a little at that. He looked at his "niece" with a strange expression: "Is that really the kind of person I am in your mind?"

Nina looked a bit aggrieved at this "uncle" whose reputation was so bad, who used to be visited every few days because of drunkenness or fights at the gambling hall. "…Otherwise, why else would the constables come to see you?"

Duncan: “…”

He sighed helplessly, walked to the shop door, and gave the two constables in deep blue uniforms a bright smile: “Good morning, gentlemen. How can I help you?”

“Mr. Duncan Strenn,” the older of the two constables spoke, polite and official. “We have found this place according to the registered address. The lead you reported to the patrol yesterday has been confirmed. On behalf of City Hall, we thank you for your contribution to maintaining order in the city-state and have brought you your reward money.”

As he finished, the younger constable stepped forward and handed over a paper packet that looked rather thick.

Nina, standing to the side, already had her eyes wide open.

Duncan had already guessed why the two constables had come, figuring it must be follow-up on the cultist den he had reported. He had not expected them to bring the reward directly to his door. Somewhat surprised, he took the packet. On the disposable wax seal at the flap he saw the words “435 Sola.” For a resident of the Lower City, this was a very generous sum.

“So there was money too…” Duncan squeezed the packet, feeling the thickness of the notes. “I didn’t even think about that at the time.”

“Of course there’s a bounty—the Governor takes cracking down on crimes inside the city-state very seriously, especially recently. Any effective report will be rewarded in a real and generous way,” the younger constable said with a smile. “And the lead you provided… was rather unusual.”

At that, Duncan could not help feeling a stir in his heart. Pretending to be casual, he asked: “By the way, I heard something wrong over there and didn’t dare get too close to look. What exactly happened?”

The two constables exchanged a glance, then took two steps forward into the shop. Nina blinked at this, then quickly went to close the door.

“We didn’t go to the scene. The Guardians were the ones handling it. But according to the reports… the scene was very brutal,” the younger constable said. He had not yet fully learned the detached, official tone of the veterans. “You did the right thing by not approaching rashly and finding the patrol to report it at once. Otherwise you would definitely have been in grave danger.”

When the young man finished, the other constable spoke as well: “Ordinary citizens do not need to know the details. We only want to remind you of one thing—cult activity in the city has been increasing lately. Do not mention your report and reward to outsiders.”

Duncan paused for a moment, then quickly understood.

This was the Lower City, where sewage and poisonous vapors sank and gathered. The things Pland least wanted to see in the light all hid in these old, winding alleys. Whenever heretics and malevolent spirits began to stir, they would inevitably hide in places like this as well.

Although the street where the antique shop stood was considered one of the more presentable parts of the Lower City and still some distance from the most rundown shantytowns, in terms of filth and hidden rot, the entire Lower City was not much different.

On the other hand, even setting aside the possibility that cult members might be hiding among the ordinary people of the Lower City, someone who “reported others to the authority and collected reward money” was very likely to be viewed with suspicion here.

Constables who knew the local situation were certainly aware of this. Their reminder was part of routine procedure, but it was also genuinely well

meant.

Duncan thought about it and felt that their warning was right.

This place really was prone to cultists—he still had that Sun emblem tucked in his pocket.

“Thank you for the reminder,” he said sincerely. He did not know what the average constable in this place was like, but at least these two made a good impression. “Would you like to sit and rest a while?”

“No need,” the older constable waved his hand and turned toward the door. “We still have patrol duties.”

The younger constable turned back before leaving. “If you come across similar leads in the future, you’re welcome to report them in time. The safety of the city-state affects every one of us.”

“Of course.” Duncan squeezed the packet in his hand, a heartfelt smile spreading across his face. “I’ve always been a good citizen who cares about order in the city-state.”

The two constables left the antique shop of “good, enthusiastic citizen Mr. Duncan.” Only when the two uniformed figures disappeared down the street did Nina finally come back to herself and look at her uncle. Uncle Duncan was opening the packet and counting the blue and green notes inside. The pleasant sound of the bills rustling made it all gradually feel real to her. “Uncle… is this really a reward from City Hall? You actually… really…”

The girl opened her mouth for a long time, but in the end she still could not bring herself to ask, “You actually really did something good?”

But Duncan knew what Nina was thinking and what she was puzzled about. He laughed. “I just reported some illegal activity on my way home yesterday. Your uncle has always been keen on public welfare.”

Nina: “…”

“But I really am surprised the reward is this high.” Before Nina could speak, Duncan lowered his head again and looked thoughtfully at the bills in his hand, muttering under his breath: “This is a lot faster than making money through business…”

There was another thought he did not say out loud: according to the information he had, there were still countless cultists from various city-states hiding in this city.

All of that was money!

Nina did not catch that for a moment. “Uncle, what did you say?”

“Nothing.” Duncan waved his hand. While he considered this new way to make money in his heart, he said casually: “Aren’t you supposed to be going to school? Head out early so you won’t be late. Right, when is Mr. Morris coming for the home visit?”

“This afternoon. I only have one class this afternoon,” Nina said, as if she had just thought of something. “Uncle, are you going out today?”

Duncan nodded. “Yeah, I need to go out for a bit, but I’ll be back before your history teacher comes.”

As soon as she heard that, Nina shot him a suspicious look. “Uncle, what are you going to do?”

Duncan gave an especially bright smile. “Your uncle is going out hunting.”

He already had an idea. Since the Sun badge worked so well and the authority handed out money so readily, he would be a fool not to use this channel. Even without the “report them and get paid” part, he would still have to make trouble for the cultists, at least to keep the area around him

safe. Now that he knew he could fleece them once more after causing them trouble, why not?

But Nina was a clever young lady. Even without knowing the rest of Duncan's secrets, she guessed at once what "hunting" in his words really meant. The girl's fine brows knit together at once. "…Uncle, this isn't right. Yesterday you said you were going to run the shop honestly, straighten things up here, and hire a shop assistant…"

"Caring about public security and running the shop steadily don't contradict each other," Duncan said with a grand wave of his hand. "Go to school. Your uncle knows what he's doing."

What he had not expected was that, after hearing this, Nina instead found a chair beside him and sat down.

"Nina?"

"Uncle, this is dangerous." Nina raised her head, her eyes fixed on Duncan.

Duncan: "Uh… actually…"

"I have to keep an eye on you." Nina sat there stubbornly. "Those two constables just said the city isn't safe right now… It's one thing to run into danger by accident, but how can you go looking for it on purpose?"

Duncan stared blankly at the girl who was only seventeen.

He suddenly realized that she truly was worried about him—in a stubborn way she believed was right and safe, she was worrying about the "Uncle Duncan" in her eyes, who had been seriously ill for many years, had a weak body, acted recklessly, and lately seemed desperate to earn money.

"I don't want a bicycle." Nina lowered her head and muttered softly.

"Go to school." Duncan suddenly let out a breath, smiling as he stepped forward and pressed a hand on Nina's head.

Nina looked up in surprise.

“You’re right. It is dangerous.” Duncan looked at Nina very seriously. “I won’t go anywhere. I’ll wait for you here in the shop.”

Chapter 86: A Better Plan

Nina went out to school. Just like many times over the past years, she once again believed in her uncle's promise, believed that Uncle would be waiting for her in the shop when she came home from school.

Or maybe she had long since stopped believing, but still stubbornly acted as if she did.

Duncan stood behind the display window on the first floor of the antique shop, watching Nina's running figure as she turned quickly at the end of the street and disappeared from his sight.

Uncle Duncan would be waiting for her in the shop when she came home. He had promised.

"AI, come here."

As the thought flashed through his mind, a stream of green flame suddenly swept through the air, and the pigeon appeared in front of Duncan.

The bird tilted its head and looked at its Master with its little bean-like eyes.

Through the connection formed by the fire of spirit form, Duncan could clearly sense the pigeon's position and its state. Although he still could not fully share its five senses, this level of perception already let him do many things.

Duncan lowered his head and looked into AI's small eyes: "You are actually very smart. You can understand everything I say, and you can do many things, right?"

The pigeon immediately flapped its wings proudly: “Loyal beyond words, loyal beyond words!”

“Then I have a bold idea I want you to try.” Duncan smiled, then took from his coat the Sun emblem that had now turned into a “cultist proximity alarm.”

He carefully wrapped the emblem in a cloth so it would not be exposed in front of ordinary people, then cautiously tied it to AI’s back with a strip of cloth.

The pigeon cooperated from beginning to end, even using its beak to help Duncan knot the strip. It seemed to understand completely what its Master wanted to do. Except for not being able to express its thoughts clearly, it was as smart as a person.

“Just fly around the city. When the emblem heats up, search for the place it resonates with, and try to narrow it down to a specific building,” Duncan told the pigeon carefully. “I will sense your position… Right, stay around the Lower City and the Crossroad District first. Don’t go to the Upper City. I’m not familiar with that area, and with only your position I won’t be able to tell the address.”

The pigeon flapped its wings and tilted its head: “Some fries?”

Duncan kept a straight face: “If you can locate even one, I can bury you in fries.”

Without another word, the pigeon flapped its wings and shot toward the door, as if afraid its Master would change his mind.

Duncan watched with a smile as the pigeon flew farther and farther into the sky. In his perception he clearly tracked the bird’s current position and the general state of its surroundings. Then he returned to the room, took a map of the city-state of Pland, and spread it on the counter. While looking at the

map, he recalled the layout details of the Lower City in his mind and, through his perception, kept tracking AI, constantly confirming the bird's position.

It turned out to be even easier than he had expected. The connection formed by the fire of spirit form was more stable than at the start. AI's flight path in his mind was almost a clear, bright guiding line. With the help of the map and his memory, it was not hard at all to pinpoint the bird.

This was a good method.

Duncan let out a light breath and shifted into a comfortable position behind the counter. He had promised Nina he would not go out and "look for danger," so of course he had to keep that promise.

But he could send the pigeon out to hunt while he stayed home writing denunciation letters…

Honestly, this was an even better plan. A pigeon that could fly was far more efficient at searching than him riding around the city in a carriage at random. Of course, there was a drawback: after finding a cultist's lair, he would no longer be able to sneak in and gather information himself. He would only get the value of reporting them.

But Duncan did not care much about that small regret. Based on his experience at the last gathering, the cultists who could be found easily were basically a bunch of small fry at the bottom, running around gathering news. Their information value was limited from the start. And if AI really sensed some "big fish"… he had follow-up ways to scoop that big fish out alone.

After all, AI's ability was not just flying around with a sensor on its back. Its main job was doing deliveries…

If he really found a big fish, he would have AI open a door on the spot and teleport the person onto the Vanished. His true body was on the ship, and there it would be even easier to question them slowly.

He also had not yet tried letting the pigeon teleport humans. He could not use innocent citizens for that kind of experiment, but those cult priests who had nothing better to do than kill people and dig out hearts were different.

When necessary, they could be “consumables.”

So Duncan leaned back in his chair, sensing AI’s position while he ran through his plan in his head, feeling more and more that it was perfect. He had already drafted his denunciation letters, interrogation outlines, and the capture and teleportation procedures. Now he only lacked a two-legged money bag known as a “Sun believer.”

The only thing left to consider in this whole plan was how he would explain it to Nina if his denunciation letters really worked and the authority later issued a reward—he had promised that young lady he would not go out “hunting.”

Duncan thought about it for a long time, then suddenly remembered something—

In this world that had already entered the industrial age, things like “banks” existed.

They were the inevitable result of the development of the economy and productivity, and also a necessary condition for it.

Although the banking system in this world was far less convenient and widespread than on Earth, it at least had basic account functions.

The city-states across the Boundless Sea had even built a circulating financial system between them on that basis. Although maintaining this system was far harder than on Earth, they had still created it.

The original master of this body had not done very well in life and had never opened an account in any city-state bank. That was quite normal in the Lower City. Usually, only respectable people from the Upper City reached the “level” where they dealt with banks. But the banks themselves were open to all citizens.

There was a bank in the Crossroad District.

Duncan made up his mind. He decided to go to the Crossroad District in a day or two and open his first bank account in this world. Then, if his activities in the human world expanded, money transfers would also become more convenient. And even if he did not think about the future, later when he wrote denunciation letters he could skip the part about leaving an address and just leave an account number.

Of course, whether this would actually work still needed to be tested when the time came. After all, the original master of this body did not have much experience dealing with the city-state’s security departments—or to be precise, not much positive experience. But Duncan still felt this approach was reasonable.

In a world that was not very safe, anonymous reports should be a normal choice for many enthusiastic citizens who wanted to be careful.

As for today… he decided to stay quietly inside the antique shop.

That was not only because he wanted to strictly keep his “agreement” with Nina. It was also because this was the first time he had let the pigeon fly so far away and then relied on the power of the spirit form fire to locate it. His lack of practice meant he had to focus especially hard, so he needed a stable environment.

Another reason was that he really ought to do business seriously for a day. Since the shop had come into his hands, it had not actually opened properly

yet.

Duncan stretched and stood up from behind the counter. He walked slowly to the front door and hung the “Open for Business” sign outside.

He now had a few more plans and a new scheme. And the beginning of all this had only been an agreement he made with a seventeen-year-old young lady. It really was… an interesting experience.

…

Near the Crossroad District, inside a ruined abandoned factory, Church guardians in long black coats edged with silver had already set up a cordon around the area. Inquisitor Vanna, wearing light armor and carrying a divine blessing greatsword on her back, walked down the sloping staircase into the abandoned basement level of the factory, accompanied by two priests of the Deep Sea.

Everything here still stayed as it had been at the start. After the first group of guardians received the report and discovered this meeting place, they had sealed the scene until now.

In the large basement, the nauseating stench of blood was especially strong, mixed with the acrid smell left when fire scorched chemical substances. cultists’ bodies lay scattered all over the floor. But aside from the corpses of these Sun heretics, the investigators had found no trace of the “attacker” at the scene—no extra bodies, not even extra scraps of clothing.

Vanna frowned slightly.

This had been a one-sided crushing battle. The attacker had been far stronger than these cultists, who were mostly ordinary people. And things seemed to have happened so suddenly that a good number of these Sun heretics had been killed before they could even resist.

Who had done this?

Was it a rogue extraordinary with a personal grudge against these cultists? Another powerful heretical cult? Or some bloody sacrificial rite gone into a runaway state, where these death-seeking heretics had summoned from the deep layers a monster they could not control at all?

The young inquisitor fell into thought.

Chapter 87: Vanna’s Investigation Conclusion

The meeting place held only the cultists’ bodies strewn all over the ground. There was no evidence that could prove the attacker’s identity, which made the investigation very difficult.

But one thing was certain: whoever had carried out this attack was definitely not an ordinary person.

A special acrid smell lingered in the air. It was the mark left when “flame” had been corrupted.

Vanna carefully inspected the oil lamps left in the basement. Beside her, a priest took special powders and reagents from his toolkit to analyze whether anything that should not exist in the Mortal Realm still remained in the lamps.

Fire was the most special thing in this world.

Fire was visible order, the handwriting of the Gods when they made a covenant with the world, the proof that “civilization still endured.” In the burning of flame, all changes in all things would leave a mark.

If an extraordinary-level battle had taken place here, then corresponding traces would definitely remain in the flames.

After the priest began his work, Vanna returned to the center of the basement and looked at the corpse of a Sun heretic lying there.

“The bones all over the body are fractured in dozens of places, as if he was hit head-on by a charging bull. It’s really hard to imagine what kind of weapon could cause this,” a coroner beside her said. “Pure blunt force. No spell traces found.”

“Blunt force… blunt force strong enough to break dozens of bones at once?” Vanna frowned slightly. “What is it, a meteor hammer a meter wide?”

The coroner shook his head: “Compared to that, the ashes over there at the far end are more suspicious.”

Vanna went to the far end of the basement and saw the “ashes” he had mentioned.

A full set of clothes lay scattered on the ground. Between the garments was fine, dark ash. It was easy to picture that there had once been a person lying here.

“No doubt, this was some kind of extraordinary power. From the traces, it may be a kind of Mutant Flame,” Vanna gave a quick judgment and said to the coroner beside her. “Normal fire can hardly burn a person into ashes like this while leaving the clothes whole afterward.”

“There are impact marks on the wall. This cultist seems to have been smashed into the wall by a huge force first, and then burned to nothing by the flames,” another priest at the scene said. “In this whole place, only this one cultist was killed by extraordinary power—and by a kind of extraordinary power we have never seen before.

“Also, in a corner of the basement we found a patch of floor that had been badly corroded by an unknown force, but no remaining matter. That may also be the effect of extraordinary power.”

“It could be a spell cast by a person, or it could be the work of an Anomaly,” Vanna said casually. “This place was discovered because a citizen reported it, right?”

“Yes. An enthusiastic citizen heard anomalous noises in the abandoned factory and reported this place to a constable and guardian changing shifts at the street corner at dusk,” the priest beside her nodded and said. “These cultists were actually very cautious. They erased their activity traces after entering the city-state and successfully hid in the Lower City without being found. If not for this attack, they might have stayed hidden even longer.”

“Now that one nest has been exposed, it means there may be more hiding in the dark,” Vanna said in a low voice. “The alleys and gutters of the Lower City will be the focus of inspections for a while. We must—”

She was halfway through speaking when a guardian hurried over from the side, holding something in his hands: “Inquisitor, look at this!”

Vanna looked up at once and saw that the guardian was holding a small tray. On the tray were several copper bullets, stained with blood and slightly misshapen.

“We found two revolvers that had been fired at the scene. These bullets should have been shot from those guns,” the guardian reported. “The blood on the bullets is very likely from the attacker!”

Vanna’s gaze fell on the bullets, and at first glance she noticed the shape of the deformed tips. The bullets were stained with blood, which meant they had been shot into living flesh. But the way the tips had shrunk and warped was not something soft, fragile flesh could cause.

Unless every one of these bullets had hit bone exactly—or the person who was shot had an extremely tough body.

And how had these bullets, which had already entered a body, ended up lying here at the scene?

Vanna thought it over carefully and saw only two possibilities. Either the attacker had performed surgery on themselves at the scene to remove the bullets, or the attacker had some special physical ability and had forced the bullets out of their body with sheer bodily strength.

Whichever it was, one thing was clear: this powerful attacker had killed all the cultists here without slowing down even after being shot several times, and then had calmly removed the bullets from their own body after it was over.

Vanna looked at her own hands.

She could do this herself. And it was precisely because she could that she understood how difficult it would be for a mortal body of ordinary flesh and blood.

“The one who killed these cultists should be an extraordinary whose body is extremely strengthened, using some kind of large blunt weapon,” after weighing it in her mind, Vanna turned to a subordinate and said: “The other side has rich combat experience, strong will, and tremendous strength. Considering the weapon used, the person is likely very tall as well and may also command some Power of Flame. A first judgment is that they are hostile to the Sun heretics, but we cannot yet be sure they stand on our side…

“Notify guardians and constables at all levels. In the near future, watch for anyone who fits these traits. If a suspected target is found, report first and do not make rash contact.”

The guardian serving as her aide lowered his head at once: “Yes, Inquisitor.”

Vanna let out a quiet breath and roughly outlined in her mind what the attacker who had rampaged through the meeting might look like: a two-meter-tall hulk swinging a giant spiked club or a meteor hammer, with superb fighting skills, calm and tenacious, able to summon flames.

That was probably about right.

…

Duncan saw off his second customer with a smile and watched the plump lady walk away slowly, feeling quite pleased.

That lady counted as a regular customer of the shop. Today she had taken a liking to a pair of vases to give as a gift to her new neighbor.

Those vases were wholesale goods from the market. Although their production date was last week, they already had eight hundred years of history. The original price was more than two hundred thousand; after the discount, it was twenty-six, and it even came with a pair of stone ornaments from the Soland Dynasty period that had left the factory last Wednesday.

The regular customer knew the goods were fake, but from start to finish she believed that Shopkeeper Duncan was genuine.

After tossing a few crumpled bills into the drawer, Duncan sat back down behind the counter, feeling his restless mood calm a little.

At least for now, running this antique shop was still a novel and interesting thing for him.

Of course, the money he earned from this little business was quite limited. The profit from selling two vases plus two ornaments was just over six sola. And after most of the day had passed, only two customers had come into his antique shop. He did not know whether that “customer flow” was a lot or a little for a normal day, but it was clearly not as promising as reporting cultists.

Duncan split off part of his attention to keep track of AI.

The pigeon was skimming low over the Fourth District. Unfortunately, the Sun charm amulet tied to its back had shown no reaction so far.

Of course, that was normal. Even though many cultists had flooded into the city-state of Pland now, they had not reached the point of blooming everywhere. On top of that, they deliberately split up and hid in all kinds of forgotten corners, so it was naturally hard to find them.

Hunting needed patience.

Duncan enjoyed the quiet time at his ease. While he watched the pigeon's movements, he also occasionally checked what was happening over on the Vanished, or controlled his body on the ship to stroll around on deck. He watched the strange sight of Alice fighting weird things on the ship and then being chased until she ran around clutching her head, and suddenly felt that this strange life of his was not bad at all.

Just then, a crisp, pleasant bell sound suddenly came from the door, cutting off his idle wandering thoughts.

"Welcome."

Duncan spoke casually as he lifted his head toward the door and saw an elderly gentleman with graying hair pushing the door open and coming in.

He was an elderly gentleman dressed with great care. His dark brown coat was new and neat, the leather shoes on his feet were polished bright, and in his hand he carried a black Gatekeeper's cane whose material was hard to tell. His hair and bow tie were both perfectly in place.

This was not the sort of outfit one usually saw in the Lower City. It looked more like someone respectable from the Crossroad District, or even the Upper City.

Duncan did not have much idea of what counted as a “respectable person” in this world, but at a glance he could tell that this elderly gentleman was not an ordinary customer.

“See anything you like?” He smiled, like a real antique shopkeeper. “If you’re meant to have it, take it home.”

Chapter 88: A Genuine Piece

The old gentleman walked into the antique shop and looked around with curiosity. The worn display window, the cheap iron shelves, and the almost randomly placed “antiques” all showed the shop’s true nature almost perfectly:

Aside from the money it took in, nothing in the whole place was real.

Even so, this elderly gentleman, whose clothes and bearing looked nothing like an ordinary citizen of the Lower City, still examined the items in the shop with great interest. Only when Duncan’s voice came from the counter did he finally turn his gaze.

“An interesting way to put it,” the old gentleman said with a laugh. “Taking away what fate has linked to you… Leaving the items aside, that sentence by itself is quite beautiful.”

“Fate alone is not enough. You also need money,” Duncan replied with a smile. “Luckily everything here is cheap. Is there anything you like?”

“Uh… I didn’t come here to buy anything,” the old gentleman started. “Actually…”

Before he could finish, Duncan went on warmly: “Even if you don’t buy, it’s still good to have a look. Maybe something will catch your eye, right?”

The old gentleman could not help showing a helpless look. “But… all your things are fake.”

“That’s right,” Duncan said as if it were only natural. “Would real goods sit here? I don’t even have a security door on this place. I rely on making sure thieves can’t make back their costs.”

The old gentleman’s face clearly twitched. He had not expected the owner of a fake-antique shop to be this frank about it. He choked for several seconds before managing: “…Then…”

“For those who are good at convincing themselves, they can treat my place as an antique shop and enjoy a bit of self-satisfaction. The realists can treat it as a general store and go for cheap and practical things. As for those who both see reality clearly and still want to fool themselves, I can only congratulate them on finding a gold brick in a trash heap. There is only one genuine piece in the whole shop, and they just happened to grab it. That is a very fated encounter.

“Anyway, spending thirty or fifty is mainly about having fun. Even if you suffer the worst scam in here, it will not cost you more than a hundred, and you will still get a fine product of modern industry. When you think about it, that’s quite a bargain, isn’t it?”

The old gentleman listened, stunned, to Duncan’s stream of crooked logic. He clearly had little experience with this kind of talk and could not react for a moment. Then his gaze suddenly fell on a corner near the counter, and his expression changed slightly.

Duncan had been happily immersed in the joy of doing business. When he noticed the shift in the old gentleman’s gaze, his heart gave a small jolt, and something came to mind. Before Duncan could speak, the old gentleman reached toward that corner and said: “This thing…”

Among a pile of junk, he had found a dagger. Its style was very old, but its condition was excellent.

He took the dagger out.

It was exactly the old item Duncan had hidden in the junk earlier, something he had brought back from the Vanished – one of only two genuine pieces in the entire antique shop.

The other lay deeper in the pile: a cast-iron cannonball.

At first Duncan tried to divert the old gentleman's attention. But then he noticed the change in the man's expression and the professional air with which he examined the patterns on the dagger's sheath. Duncan realized at once:

This old gentleman might be a professional.

Duncan frowned slightly and let his gaze run over the dagger.

It was not actually a big problem. The thing was not an supernatural item. It did not carry the curse, corruption, or any other "specialty of the sea". Even though it was taken from the Vanished, in essence it was no different from an ordinary relic.

It was a plain, unremarkable object. If Duncan reacted too strongly, that would look more suspicious.

"This thing…" the old gentleman said again. He looked up at Duncan with some surprise and asked: "Is it also one of the shop's 'goods'?"

He spoke very gently, but the meaning under his words was clear: how had a real item ended up mixed in with this pile of fakes? Was it some kind of mistake?

From the other man's reaction, Duncan guessed at once that he knew his stuff. Pretending not to recognize the item would not be right. It was better to admit it just enough. He reined in his smile and put on a slightly

mysterious look: “You see? You have just met something tied to you by fate.”

Then he cleared his throat and said seriously: “Most of the goods in this shop are discounted. A few are exceptions, like the one in your hand.”

The old gentleman immediately looked back at the shelves. His eyes swept over those “modern handicrafts” whose price tags listed tens of thousands, crossed out and marked down to a few dozen. Who knew what he was imagining. Suddenly this shabby, bluffing antique shop seemed mysterious and interesting in his eyes.

He carefully set the dagger on the counter, as if he was about to ask the price, but just then a bell rang at the door and cut him off.

Duncan looked toward the door and saw Nina’s figure.

“Uncle Duncan, I’m back!” Nina called toward the counter the moment she stepped through the door, without even lifting her head. “Has Mr. Morris arrived yet?”

“I haven’t seen him,” Duncan said, glancing around the shop. “I’m just serving…”

Before he finished, the old gentleman in front of him coughed twice and pointed to himself: “My name is Morris.”

Duncan: “…?”

“Mr. Morris!” Nina now saw the old gentleman at the counter and cried out in surprise. Then, like any student who ran into a teacher after school, she visibly tensed up. She snapped to attention, standing straight. “Good afternoon!”

Duncan looked at Nina, then at the old man, his gaze going back and forth twice. The air finally turned properly awkward.

“I wanted to introduce myself at the start,” the old gentleman said, spreading his hands helplessly. “But before I could speak, you cut me off, and then you began showing me the goods in your shop…”

Nina now understood what had happened. Then she noticed the dull-looking dagger on the counter and hurried two steps forward: “Teacher, don’t buy that! Everything in my family’s shop is fake!”

Duncan gave the young lady a strange look. He thought to himself that this child was far too honest. In front of her teacher it had taken her less than a second to sell out her own family’s secrets. Though, given the level of the shop’s goods and Morris’s eye as a history expert, whether she sold them out or not did not really matter…

On the other side, after hearing Nina’s words, the old gentleman Morris shook his head and pointed to the dagger on the counter: “This one is real.”

Nina froze: “…Huh?”

“This dagger should date back about one century. It was one of the utility daggers favored by seafarers from central city-states such as Pland and Lunsa at the time. But because the forges that made them went bankrupt, and because items taken to sea are easily damaged by wind and waves, very few survive today, and most are in terrible condition…”

As he spoke, Morris carefully picked up the dagger from the counter. He drew the blade out a little and went on in an amazed tone: “I… I have never seen one in such good condition. It is as if it was still in normal use not long ago. The blade is sharp enough to slide through paper. There is not a single flaw on it…”

“It even still has its original sheath,” Duncan added from the side. “If you look closely, you will see even the clasp on the back of the sheath is original.”

Hearing this, Morris hurried to examine the sheath and its fittings again. The surprise in his eyes grew even stronger. “This… I really did not notice before… My heavens! This thing is like it was just taken out of the pocket of a sailor from a century ago! If I did not have enough confidence in my own eye, I would suspect it was an amazing forgery… But even the patterns where the blade joins the hilt, and that special flaw at the end of the hilt, they all…”

Here he suddenly grew uncertain. He looked up at Duncan, then at Nina. The history expert actually lost his confidence: “It really isn’t a forgery?”

When Nina heard this, she quickly waved her hands: “My uncle could never fake something this real…”

Duncan’s eyelid twitched. He looked at his niece: “Go upstairs and do your homework!”

Nina blinked. “I don’t have any homework today…”

“Then go read a book!”

Nina stuck out her tongue and tiptoed toward the stairs. After a few steps she looked back at her history teacher: “Mr. Morris, don’t forget you’re here for a home visit…”

“Of course. I have many things to talk about with Mr. Duncan,” Morris replied with a broad smile. The old gentleman looked full of energy. “Go upstairs and read for now. Don’t worry, I won’t complain about my own student behind her back.”

Nina looked doubtfully at Uncle Duncan and at her teacher. She clearly had not expected the “home visit” to begin like this.

But the next moment, for some reason, she suddenly smiled.

The girl ran lightly up the stairs.

Chapter 89: Something Was Wrong with Nina

Watching Nina run lightly up the stairs, Duncan still did not understand what was going on. He scratched his hair in confusion and muttered: “What is that child grinning about…”

Then he heard Morris’s voice from beside the counter: “To be honest, you are very different from the impression I had of you, Mr. Duncan.”

“Very different?” Duncan raised one eyebrow. “What kind of impression did you have of me?”

As he spoke, he walked out from behind the counter, hung a “Temporarily Closed” sign on the door, and moved a chair to the side of the counter. Once he was sure the other man was a teacher here for a home visit and not an ordinary guest, it would clearly be improper to keep him standing.

“Thank you,” Morris said with a nod. After sitting down, he looked toward Duncan with a gentle, scholarly smile. “I have never met you, but I have heard of Nina’s family situation from some channels. Forgive me for being rude, but according to the rumors I heard, Nina has an uncle who drinks, gambles, and has a violent temper. That child lives in a terrible home atmosphere, so at school she almost has no friends. The other students are not very willing to talk to her.”

Duncan was at the side brewing coffee. When he heard Morris’s words, his hands paused for two seconds without thinking. Then he finished what he was doing at his usual pace. He carried two cups of coffee back to the

counter and pushed one toward the old man: “I hope you don’t mind that I only have this cheap stuff here. Even the best coffee in the Lower City is about this level.”

He sat down across from the old man. Each of them held a steaming cup of coffee. The ancient dagger lay between them, but for now neither of them paid it any attention.

“Strictly speaking… those rumors are all true,” Duncan said slowly. “I was ill before, a serious illness. When painkillers stopped working, I could only rely on strong liquor to numb my nerves. That was a very ruined period of time. Unfortunately, it happened to fall in several key years of Nina’s adolescence. Now it seems that it affected her more than I thought.”

Morris studied Duncan carefully. After a long moment, he spoke in a thoughtful tone: “Is that so? But to me, you do not look like someone who has just come out of such a state. You look more like a gentleman who has never fallen into it at all, someone who has always been cheerful and positive. The quick wit and humor you show when you speak do not look like they were dulled by alcohol.”

As he spoke, he took a sip of coffee. He did not comment on the drink. He only added as if in passing: “I think my judgment of people is usually quite accurate.”

“Maybe I just adjusted my mindset quickly,” Duncan said with a relaxed smile. He had to admit the old man’s eye for people was very sharp, but he believed that no matter how sharp it was, it could not see the secret hidden inside this body, so he did not feel nervous at all. “Nina is almost an adult. I am her only guardian. I have to show a bit of responsibility.”

“In any case, that is good for the child,” Morris said, giving Duncan a deep look. “She is at a crucial stage in her studies. Many people say that after graduating from a public high school, you can only go and tighten bolts in a

factory. But they always overlook one thing: knowledge itself is a precious wealth. One day in your life it will suddenly show its meaning, and that is often when you no longer have a chance to return to school."

The old gentleman spoke and then shook his head. "Sadly, most of the parents I have dealt with do not agree with this. Their attention is fixed on making their children graduate as soon as possible and find a job."

When Duncan heard this, he suddenly felt very close to him. He knew this talk well. When he had been a teacher, he had often said similar things to students or to their parents, but no one had listened to him…

But soon Duncan put away this feeling of meeting a colleague. After he thought for a moment about the environment he was in now, he shook his head slightly:

"Because this is the Lower City, Mr. Morris. Your view is very wise and far-sighted, but most people here really do need to pay off last month's bills as soon as they can. You cannot say their sight is too short just because of that."

"That is true. Many people actually want to look farther ahead, but the high walls of life always block our view of the distance," the old gentleman said with a sigh. "Sorry. When you soak in books for too long, you tend to ignore the practical problems of life… You are someone who thinks things through. It seems some of my worries were unnecessary."

"Worries?" Duncan frowned. "By the way, has something happened with Nina at school recently? Have her grades dropped?"

"Her grades have always been very good, but recently… she has been a bit absent-minded," Morris said, choosing his words. "She daydreams in class, sleeps during self-study, and even gets distracted in lab. In last week's

chemistry class, she even set the lab bench on fire. These things never happened before… at least they never happened with her."

The old gentleman paused, then added: "In the quiz two days ago, her results did not actually drop. But if this state continues, it is hard to say what her grades will be by the time she graduates. It is true that the paths open after public high school are limited, but there is still a difference between assembling machines in a factory in the Lower City and maintaining a steam core in the Cathedral in the Upper City. As Nina's guardian, you should take this seriously."

"Nina has been absent-minded in class a lot lately?" Duncan frowned again. "She has not told me anything about that…"

"A girl this age will not tell you much," Morris said, shaking his head. "At first I thought something had happened at home, or that her 'drunken uncle' had done something lately and that was affecting her state at school. That is why I came for this home visit. But now it seems… that is not the reason."

For a while, Duncan did not speak. He tried to recall whether Nina had showed any odd behavior in front of him over the past few days, and thought over her daily routine. After a few seconds, Morris asked again: "You are the person who knows her best. Has that child had any odd changes lately? For example, not resting well, or feeling unwell?"

Duncan thought for a long time and could only spread his hands: "… Shameful as it is, I cannot think of an answer."

He really could not. A week ago, he had not even known Nina. How could he know what changes she had compared to before?

Morris did not seem surprised by Duncan's answer. He had probably already lowered his expectations for "Nina's uncle" based on neighborhood rumors before he came. So now he simply said out of habit: "You should

pay more attention to her. Especially for a girl this age, material support alone is not enough."

When Duncan heard this, a thought suddenly popped into his mind: "Could she be in love?"

To be honest, this idea came at least in part from Zhou Ming's experience as a People's Teacher…

When Morris heard this, his expression turned a little strange. The old man gave Duncan a weird look: "It is a girls' school…"

Duncan thought for a moment and said with a serious face: "A girls' school is fine too."

Morris's eyes widened slightly.

This old gentleman, who had always devoted himself to his studies, was deeply shaken.

"Ahem, all right, I was only speaking casually," Duncan said. Seeing the old man's reaction, he knew this topic might be a bit beyond his range, so he quickly coughed twice to break the awkwardness. "I will have a good talk with Nina. She should be willing to tell me."

"Ah… oh, of course," the old gentleman finally reacted. He still seemed caught in his shock, and his words came half a beat slow. "From what I know… Nina is a very honest, very straightforward child. If you talk to her properly, she should not resist much."

Duncan nodded: "Besides that, is there anything else? Has Nina been strange in any other way at school lately?"

"Other than being absent-minded and distracted, not really," the old gentleman said after thinking for a moment, then shook his head. "I mainly

came today to talk about this and to understand her real home situation. By the way, speaking of that, Nina's parents, was it because of…"

"The accident eleven years ago," Duncan said. "There is an official record of it. The chemical plant leak in the Sixth District."

"So that was it," the old gentleman sighed. "I remember that accident. At the time, my daughter and I happened to be near the Crossroad District. When the chemical plant leaked, the disturbance was huge. The affected crowd even pushed all the way to the edge of the Upper City… The later investigation said many cultists took the chance to cause trouble that night, and that they were the ones who sabotaged the plant…"

Duncan's heart moved. Keeping his face calm, he asked casually: "Wasn't there also a big fire in the Lower City that night?"

"A fire? I do not remember any big fire," Morris said with a frown. "You must be mistaken."

"…Seems I remembered wrong," Duncan said with a smile, pressing his forehead. "I really should stay away from alcohol."

Chapter 90: First Big Business at the antique shop

Duncan had already expected Morris’s reaction. He had only brought up that topic to confirm his guess.

Just as his earlier information had said, someone like Morris, an ordinary person, knew nothing about any great fire. That sea of flames existed only in Nina’s and Duncan’s memories.

Strictly speaking, until Duncan took control of this body, that fire had existed only in Nina’s own memory.

The topic passed quickly. Morris did not become suspicious because of this strange question. Next, he told Duncan a bit about Nina’s studies and her class, and asked some questions about Nina’s family.

It was clear that this elderly gentleman, who cared so much about his students, had wanted to know these things for a long time. But Nina’s uncle’s rotten, degenerate life had delayed it until today.

The memories Duncan inherited from this body were limited. He actually did not know the answers to many of the old gentleman’s questions. Fortunately, his mind was flexible. He could answer by relying on what memories he had and filling in the rest with imagination. As for the things he really could not handle… he pushed them onto his former decadent life, the harm of alcohol, and swore that he would turn over a new leaf.

He was very experienced with “home visits”. He knew what teachers usually asked and what they cared about. Even though this was now a different world and a different identity, that experience still came in handy.

When they finally finished this “proper business”, Mr. Morris’s attention, as expected, fell on the second thing he cared about most.

The old gentleman looked at the well-preserved antique dagger on the counter. The eagerness in his eyes was obvious to anyone: “Is this thing… for sale?”

Duncan smiled at once: “This is an antique shop.”

The antiques in an antique shop were, of course, for sale.

At this moment he had thought it through. The dagger came from the Vanished, but the more he thought about it, the more he felt there was no real danger in selling it. There were countless items aboard the Vanished, and not all of them were connected to anything supernatural. A dagger like this, put anywhere else, was just an ordinary antique. Why shouldn’t he sell it?

Compared to the pile of fakes in the shop, the cargo holds of the Vanished were the real way to make money.

Once his thoughts fell into place, the world suddenly felt wide open. Duncan’s mood brightened. He suddenly realized he had been sitting on a treasure hoard all along. Those things he had treated as scrap were treasures simply placed in the wrong spot, just waiting for some wealthy, fated buyer to appear. Looking at the Mr. Morris in front of him… wasn’t this a fated buyer?

Morris had no idea what schemes were turning in the mind of the antique shop’s owner. All of his attention was now on the well-preserved dagger. After hesitating for quite a while, he finally spoke carefully: “How much?”

Duncan: “…”

The world did not feel wide anymore, because he had no idea what price to name.

Even if he had inherited this body’s memories completely, he still would not know what price to ask. From the day this shop opened, it had never sold anything genuine. And antiques had no fixed pricing standard. He was a complete layman. What would be a proper price to ask right now?

Duncan thought fast. First he ruled out following the price tags on the fake goods in the shop and asking two or three hundred thousand. Even if this dagger was genuine and in excellent condition, it was only a little over a hundred years old. And from what the old gentleman had just said, daggers of this type from a century ago were rare but not unique. The sailors back then had used them as utility knives. That alone meant its value was limited.

It was relatively recent, not unique, and had no special historical background. It was a modern piece in excellent condition, but with only average value for collectors or display. Mr. Morris clearly liked it, which let him raise the price a little, but not too much. Besides, the man was Nina’s teacher. That relationship also had to be taken into account.

Duncan thought his way around the whole circle in just a couple of seconds. In the end, he still shook his head and smiled: “You name the price, Mr. Morris. You are the teacher Nina respects the most. I really can’t charge you the same as an ordinary customer.”

He understood clearly how limited his knowledge was. For him to guess a reliable number now was harder than getting Goathead to stay silent for three days. Whether he went too high or too low, it would just show how little he understood. Better to give Morris a step to stand on and let the old gentleman help him judge the value.

He believed Mr. Morris could probably guess his intention.

As for whether he would lose out on this deal… Duncan was quite relaxed about that.

It was a business with no cost at all. How much could he really lose? With no preparation, he could still get an unexpected sum of money, gain some experience, and get to know a professional in the field of history. In any case, it was still a profit.

Morris fell into serious thought.

He did not think about too many other things. Most of his attention was still on the dagger.

“Three thousand… three thousand four hundred sola. That’s my estimate,” Morris finally said. He seemed to have weighed it very carefully before settling on that number. “Mr. Duncan, you might feel this price is a bit low. But you have to consider the dagger’s age and its place in history. An item like this, one that isn’t unique, depreciates heavily on the market. Of course, its condition is very good. That is rare. But you also have to consider that not every collector will be interested in it…”

The old gentleman seemed to be working to explain the reasoning behind his price. Duncan listened while his mind started to calculate quickly.

In the Lower City, the entire monthly expenses for an ordinary family of three came to just a bit over two hundred sola. And most commoners in the Lower City ended each month with almost nothing left over, if they had any surplus at all.

This dagger was worth almost a year and a half of income for an ordinary Lower City household.

This was what a “genuine piece” was worth here. And this was not even a particularly valuable genuine piece.

He did not know whether he should sigh over the antique trade's "three years with no business, one deal to eat for three years", or over the shocking gap between lower-city life and the so-called refined hobbies of upper society.

Maybe he should simply sigh over how very rich this old gentleman in front of him was.

"Deal." He let out a quiet breath and said to the old gentleman with a smile.

He did not even consider wasting time haggling.

No matter what, this was a huge sum for Nina and him right now. Reporting a cultist den did not bring in anywhere near this much.

Not long ago he had still been worrying about ways to make money. Now he suddenly found it was no longer such an urgent problem.

The world was unpredictable.

Morris, however, felt Duncan had agreed a bit too readily. He even felt a little guilty about it: "Actually… at this price, you are taking a loss. By a normal estimate, given how many of these daggers are still in existence and its condition, it should be at least ten or twenty percent more expensive… but…"

The old gentleman rubbed his nose, looking a little embarrassed: "Recently I have been spending quite a lot collecting old items. My funds are a bit tight…"

This old gentleman was even more honest than Duncan had imagined.

"I think it's a very good price. Let's take the difference as 'fate'," Duncan said with a smile. Then, as if he suddenly remembered something, he got up and went behind the counter. "By the way, to celebrate this 'big deal', I have a little gift for you."

Morris watched with curiosity and some expectation as Duncan took a small purple crystal pendant out of one of the pigeonholes behind the counter.

The old gentleman had sharp eyes. At a glance he saw the tag from some glassworks still hanging on the pendant.

Morris: “…”

“A pendant that calms the mind and wards off evil. The crystal has been blessed. It can show the right direction amid illusions and the curse. Ancient Hypnotists used it to protect their minds against the dangers lurking in the dreamscape,” Duncan said, pushing the pendant toward him with a very serious expression. “It has protected one generation of Masters after another. Now it is fated to be yours…”

Morris hesitated, then pointed at the tag on the pendant: “But it says here it was made by Johnnie Glassworks…”

“I know. I forgot to tear that off,” Duncan said, face expressionless, as he pulled off the tag. “It’s a free gift. How could my shop have that many genuine items to give away?”

Morris stared for a second, then could not help laughing: “All right, fair enough. Thank you very much for the ‘gift’. With this, I hope my daughter will nag me a bit less.”

As he spoke, he accepted the pendant, then fumbled in his coat for a moment before taking out a bank checkbook. “I didn’t bring that much cash with me. This bank check can be cashed at any Pland City-State bank in the Crossroad District or the Upper City. Is that acceptable?”

Duncan smiled: “Of course.”

As he spoke, his gaze fell on Morris’s bank check.

When he first heard Nina mention her history teacher, he had already felt some doubt. Now that he had actually met Mr. Morris, that doubt stirred again.

From his clothes, his manner, and his professional skill in history and artifacts, this old gentleman was clearly not an ordinary person. Even without knowing what the Upper City was really like, Duncan could tell that a scholar like this should have been teaching at a university in the Upper City, not at a public school in the Crossroad District.

Even if he set aside all other factors, there was one obvious question:

Could an ordinary public school history teacher really pull out a year and a half of a Lower City family’s income so easily, just to buy a collectible he happened to like?

Chapter 91: Distorted History

The so-called “public schools” of the Pland city-state were completely different from the true universities in the Upper City. These schools, funded and supported by City Hall, were not institutions for training real scholars. Their main purpose was to train skilled workers for the factories in the Lower City and for the Church’s steam engines, and to give the general public basic literacy education in the process.

Under that premise, it was easy to imagine the level of resources at the public school in the Crossroad District.

This was Duncan’s first time meeting Morris in person, but even from a first impression he could tell the old gentleman’s academic skill was extraordinary. This was a man who could pick out a genuine relic from a pile of junk at a glance and state its year and historical background with accuracy. An expert like that would have been more than qualified to teach in a university in the Upper City.

Frankly, leaving such a deep reservoir of knowledge in a public school in the Crossroad District was a waste. Nina had already said that almost none of her classmates cared about what the old gentleman-professor taught. If they managed to stay awake through a whole class, it already counted as “respecting the teacher”.

And on top of that, Mr. Morris had just taken out a large amount of money to buy a dagger from a century ago. People who carried a bank checkbook around were rarely ordinary citizens.

Duncan thought it over. Asking bluntly, “So why are you so rich?” would be too abrupt. But with a bit of verbal polish, the question could sound quite natural:

“Actually, I’m a little curious. For a scholar like you, why stay on as a teacher at a public school in the Crossroad District?”

“…You’re not the first to ask me that,” Morris said with a small smile, as if he was already used to such questions. He carefully put his things away as he spoke. “But there isn’t much to it. I’m old, and I grew tired of the intense academic atmosphere at those universities in the Upper City. Rather than fighting with youngsters for the little funding that exists, I would rather find a quiet place to finish my research. And if, in my later years, I can pass my knowledge on to more young people, isn’t that a good thing?”

The old man did not seem to be telling the whole truth. But Duncan saw that he did not wish to dwell on it, so he did not push. He only added casually: “But Nina told me her classmates don’t really treasure what you teach them. In the harsh life of the Lower City, isn’t chasing after the glory of the ancient kingdom of Critt a bit too distant?”

“Even in the darkest, filthiest alleyway, as long as a mind with spiritual insight is still thinking, ‘history’ will always have value,” Morris said, shaking his head. “It is precisely because of the thousands of years of history behind us that we have managed to come this far.

“Mortal life is very brief. It is our inheritance of history, and our respect for it, that lets civilization live far beyond the limits of any single person. That is also the key difference between us and those strange, blind things in the Deep Sea. They may be ancient, but they do not know how to record civilization, and so they can never truly wipe us out.

“Of course, Mr. Duncan, you’re not wrong either. In the Lower City, very few people are willing to listen to my long lectures. But even if I manage to

influence only one single student, I still feel that my years have not been wasted."

Morris spoke slowly and calmly. Then he seemed to realize something, and a gentle, apologetic smile appeared on his face: "Forgive me. Occupational habit. I started preaching a bit."

"It's all right. I think it's very worthwhile 'preaching'," Duncan said at once, waving his hand. "To be honest, I'm quite happy to talk with you. Look, you're a history expert, and I'm an antique dealer. In a way, we're colleagues."

[From the "teacher" side, they were colleagues too, Duncan added silently.]

"To be honest, if I judged only from the first impression when I walked into this antique shop… I really wouldn't believe your word 'colleague'," Morris said, spreading his hands. "But now I somewhat believe it. You at least have one genuine piece."

Duncan kept a very calm expression. In his heart he thought: it was far more than one genuine piece. The moment the old gentleman filled out the bank check, Duncan had already mentally gone over every cargo hold on the Vanished. If he weren't worried about crashing the market, he would already be planning the interior design of his eighth branch shop.

Steadying himself inside, Duncan kept up his relaxed smile: "Nina told me you're actually more specialized in ancient history, especially the history around the ancient kingdom of Critt?"

"Strictly speaking, there is only 'after', not 'before'," Morris corrected at once. "The ancient kingdom of Critt was the Dawn of Civilization in the Deep Sea era. Before that ancient kingdom, there was the Great Annihilation. That was the break in civilization. No one can say clearly what the world looked like before that point in time. At best we have

contradictory accounts from the wild tales passed down in various city-states."

Duncan looked thoughtful: "A break in civilization… like a 'Horizon Limit' crossing the river of history…"

Morris clearly heard that term for the first time: "Horizon Limit?"

"A concept," Duncan explained. "Applied to the event of the Great Annihilation, you can see it as an invisible wall in time. All information on the far side of the wall can't be transmitted to this side. Whether it's optical observation or chains of cause and effect, everything is cut off at that boundary. You can never stand on one side and learn what happened on the other, as if the timeline of all things only suddenly appears starting from that boundary."

"That is a very interesting description!" The old gentleman's eyes opened a little wider, and there was even a faint light in them. "A Horizon Limit across history… a wall of time… Yes, that is very apt! Mr. Duncan, forgive my earlier mistaken impression and… my condescension. You are more professional than I thought. Do you also often study ancient history?"

"No, I don't know much about ancient history. I just have a flexible way of thinking, and sometimes I come up with odd metaphors," Duncan said modestly at once. He knew he should appear a bit ignorant right now. "But I really am curious about the Great Annihilation. You just said that in formal scholarship there is no accepted view of history before the Great Annihilation, but there are many conflicting accounts in the 'unofficial histories' of different city-states? What sort of records are those?"

"Just wild tales and strange legends… but yes, I've studied a few," Morris said slowly after thinking for a moment. "For example, there was once a record in Pland. It was a hand-copied manuscript from New City-State

Calendar year 1069. The original no longer exists. In that copy, the world before the Great Annihilation was described like this:

“The world was a sphere, floating in a boundless sea of stars. Countless celestial bodies lit the night as stars. In the sky there was one Sun and three Moons. Humans occupied three continents. One of the continents was frozen in ice year-round, so people built a device called ‘the dome’ to cover the land and create ‘eternal spring’. The dome’s power source was modeled after the Sun in the sky and used some component in seawater as fuel, almost everlasting…”

Morris paused there, as if giving Duncan a moment to think, remember, and sort things out. Then he continued:

“And on an island near Cold Harbor, explorers found an inscription carved into rock. It also described the world before the Great Annihilation. Scholars put in huge effort to decipher it, and were left deeply puzzled.

“The stone text said that a homeland called ‘Homeworld’ had already been exhausted. All people had boarded a gigantic ship named ‘Abinix’. This great vessel could cross the sea of stars and used dust and gas captured from the void as fuel. After the ship had sailed for forty-seven thousand days and nights, it was suddenly caught in a ‘great flash and vortex’. The ship then broke apart and vanished in the whirlpool. The descendants survived by rising from the sea and left their memories of the homeland carved in a cave.

“Of course, even those records are not as bizarre as the tales left by the Elves of Lightwind Harbor.

“Elves have lifespans of a thousand years. Their history should have been more detailed and reliable than that of any short-lived race. But for some reason, the history of Lightwind Harbor is the most fragmented and absurd of all city-states. Many of their archives have even been twisted by some

unknown force into unreadable Lost Tomes. Because the corruption is so severe, they had to be sealed away. And in the narrative poems the Elves pass down by word of mouth, the world before the Great Annihilation is described like this:

“The world was a dream, a single breath taken by the Great Demon God Saslokar while half-asleep. The Elves were born in that dream and kept Saslokar sleeping peacefully. But one day, this demon god dreamed of a Great Flood. Saslokar woke in fright, and the flood spilled out of the dream into the Mortal Realm. The Elves were swept into the Mortal Realm by that flood. The demon god Saslokar vanished upon waking, and the Elves could never return to that peaceful, gentle homeland. So, after the flood, they settled down in the Deep Sea era.”

Chapter 92: Endless Speculation

Morris let out a sigh.

“When people like us, who dig through history, fight our whole lives to come up against the high wall of the Great Annihilation,” he said, “when we spend our lives seeking relics and comparing ancient texts, trying to glimpse the scenery on the other side of that wall… what we end up facing is just this kind of bizarre, absurd stuff.”

Deep weariness and frustration lay on the old man’s face. He looked like a traveler who had spent most of his life on the road, reached the end of the journey, and still could not see the destination, yet had to accept the limits of the Mortal Realm.

“History before the Great Annihilation is shattered and full of contradictions,” he went on. “The records of different city-states are like strange tales, or like dreams that have nothing to do with each other… There is no decisive proof that any one record is correct, and no theory that can pull all these contradictions together.”

Duncan did not speak right away, because his thoughts rose and fell like waves. In these unbelievable “scraps of unofficial history” that Morris described, he felt as if he were going through a baptism in a storm of information.

As a “foreigner” who had lived through an information age and had a decent talent for association, he could imagine or guess at many things from the other man’s words—

The dome that covered the whole continent might have been some kind of artificial ecological system, a power system that shared a source with the Sun, drawing fuel from substances in the seawater. That might have been fusion technology.

The gigantic ships that sailed through the void, catching dust and gas clouds in space for power, might have been one or several colony starships.

As for the so-called dream of a demon god… and the seawater that flowed from that dream into the Mortal Realm… he could not picture what that was for the moment, but it sounded like a fantasy concept, something completely different in style from the technological feel of the first two strands of history.

He could find explanations or guesses for many things, yet these things still could not be pieced together in any way.

Just as Morris had said, they were more like separate dreams that had no connection, each sketching a completely different Pre-Cataclysm History.

They were contradictory and broken, and could not be used at all to rebuild what the world before the Great Annihilation had looked like.

“Maybe you are right,” Morris’s voice came from behind the counter, breaking Duncan’s thoughts. The old man held his forehead, his tone low. “Around the key event of the Great Annihilation, there may be a kind of ‘Horizon Limit’. We cannot observe the ‘events’ beyond that horizon, so the history before the Great Annihilation becomes, for us, a concept we can never truly trace back.”

Looking at the emotional Morris, Duncan’s own thoughts still did not stop. Little by little, he instead came up with a rather bold idea: “Then… what if all those records are true?”

Morris raised his eyes and looked at Duncan in surprise: “Oh?”

“What if all those records are true?” Duncan rubbed his chin and spoke in a thoughtful tone. “What if the history recorded by each city-state or each race really is the true shape of what they knew as ‘the world before the Great Annihilation’?

“Maybe our ancestors ten thousand years ago really came from completely different ‘homelands’, with entirely different civilizations. The Great Annihilation trapped these exiles from different worlds on this sea. Before the legacy of their civilizations was completely cut off, the descendants of those exiles barely managed to record what they knew. Ten thousand years later, those records became the ‘contradictory histories’ that trouble scholars today…”

His thoughts grew livelier. After a pause, he went on: “Maybe the nature of the Great Annihilation was not the world’s Doomsday at all, but a ‘Great teleportation’.”

Morris stared at Duncan in surprise and suddenly said: “…The Brock Bendis school’s hypothesis? The World Drifting Theory? That is a rather obscure school of thought. I did not expect your study of ancient history to be so deep.”

He meant it as praise, but Duncan instead became a bit dazed: from the sound of it, someone had already thought of this possibility?!

He blinked, but did not let his surprise show. He only acted as if he were following the topic and said: “It’s just bits and pieces I picked up, but I really like this hypothesis.”

“I like it too—though it is very obscure,” Morris shook his head. “But like every other hypothesis, without evidence it can only stay a hypothesis.

“The Clark school once suggested that interference from Subspace with the Mortal Realm twisted all historical records. The Vilentim school believes

that the world before the Great Annihilation was made of countless separate lattices that were cut off from one another. The scholars of the Bologna City-State even insist that the world before the Great Annihilation never existed at all, and that all records of Pre-Cataclysm History are illusions made by Shadows in Subspace…

“To say something I probably shouldn’t, even some heretical cults have their own take on world history. The Enders, who worship Subspace, firmly believe that Doomsday has already begun and is chasing our civilization along the river of history, swallowing it piece by piece. The contradictory historical records of the city-states are, in their view, the result of real history slowly being torn apart by Subspace. The Great Annihilation is a barrier standing in front of Doomsday. When the history after the Great Annihilation is also torn apart by corruption, that will be the day the whole world falls into Subspace…”

The more Duncan heard, the more shocked he became. After a long time, he finally shook his head without thinking: “I really did not know there were so many strange and wild theories…”

“Ordinary people do not step into this field,” Morris said. “Studying history from the angle of occult studies is a dangerous business, after all. But there is one clear truth: if tens of thousands of scholars have already spent centuries, even millennia, groping in a field that seems to have no exit, then they have already put forward every hypothesis that can be imagined.”

Duncan slowly understood what the old man meant.

For people who had truly spent their lives buried in stacks of texts and piles of relics, putting forward some hypothesis that could explain the present was simple. As scholars, they were never short on imagination or vision.

What they lacked was evidence—evidence that could prove even one of those hypotheses.

“…No evidence at all has survived?” Duncan asked. “Nothing at all from before the Great Annihilation, nothing that can prove that any of those ‘unofficial histories’ have a basis in fact?”

“None has been found so far,” Morris said slowly. “Ten thousand years of time, and in between them one Dark Age after another. Countless city-states have risen and fallen across the Boundless Sea. It is far too hard for anything from the Age of Antiquity to survive…

“What has made it down to us is either hand-copied manuscripts of doubtful origin, or stories passed on by word of mouth. And even those may have already changed form during the process of being passed along.”

Duncan did not speak for a moment.

In the depths of his mind, far away on the Vanished, the waves rose and fell gently. The boundless sea was as it had always been, covering the whole world.

It also covered all truths that might exist.

He could not help sighing: “Studying ancient history really is full of difficulties.”

“Yes. We face not only shattered ‘years’, but also an empty present with nothing to lean on,” Morris sighed. “On the limited land of the city-states, if there were anything we could dig up, we would have dug it up long ago. If we cannot, then it means the things that can prove our history are hidden where mortals cannot reach.”

“Like the seafloor?” Duncan suddenly said.

“The seafloor? Ha, what a frightening and bold idea,” Morris laughed. “But that really is the last hope many historians cling to when they reach the end of their road…

“They imagine that the seafloor holds the evidence, mountains of relics, cities of ancient civilizations, and ruins that can explain everything. But what use is that? When we dive down, we can only touch Shadows. Mortals cannot reach the deepest places of this world.”

He paused for a moment, then spoke again: “But that did give rise to another hypothesis… It never became its own school of thought, but quite a few people have guessed that the lost ‘Old World’ in history is actually just below the surface of the Boundless Sea. Some even try to locate it exactly at a certain ‘depth’ between the Abyssal Deep Sea, and the Spirit Realm—the world from before the Great Annihilation lies sleeping at that depth.”

“Why do they say that?” Duncan was curious. This very serious, yet completely baseless hypothesis caught his interest.

Morris thought for a moment and explained: “Because many broken ancient histories mention that the world before the Great Annihilation was covered on all sides by a ‘Starry Sky’. And, as everyone knows, the ‘Starry Sky’ lies right at the boundary between the Abyssal Deep Sea, and the Spirit Realm.”

Duncan almost choked on his own saliva: “Cough, cough… what?”

“Are you all right?” Morris was startled by Duncan’s reaction. “That should not be anything unbelievable…”

“I am fine, I just got too caught up in what you were saying and choked,” Duncan quickly waved his hand. “The Starry Sky is between the Abyssal Deep Sea, and the Spirit Realm, of course I know that, of course I know…”

Chapter 93: This Is Common Sense

Duncan quickly adjusted his expression and his mood so he would not look like a “foreigner” with scrambled common sense. But his thoughts could no longer calm down. They surged like stormy waves.

It turned out that when you suddenly arrived in a strange and anomalous world, then in those first days—no matter how strong your ability to adapt, no matter how well you acted—at any moment, some ordinary piece of “common sense” could smack you in the face with the local worldview. Ordinary historical knowledge could be learned in a systematic way. Deep, specialized knowledge did not matter much in daily life. But “common sense” was something that only made you yell in shock when you ran right into it.

In this world, there were no stars in the sky. That was common sense.

In this world, the Starry Sky lay in the Deep Sea, at the boundary between the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep Sea. That was also common sense.

As for this second piece of so-called “common sense”, Duncan could only think: [What the hell.]

He had never come into contact with this field and had never gone down to that depth. He had raced the Vanished through the depths of the Spirit Realm. He had seen the chaotic streams of light that leaked in from Subspace in the ship’s lowest deck. But he had never seen that “Starry Sky” between the waters of the Abyssal Deep and the Spirit Realm… and that happened to be a blind spot in his knowledge so far.

As Duncan kept up his side of the conversation with Morris, his mind spun quickly.

Stars… hidden deep in seawater… What kind of strange sight would that be? Was the “Starry Sky” Morris spoke of the same “Starry Sky” Duncan knew about? What was the true shape of the place where the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep met? Was it a stretch of even deeper, darker ocean? Or was it a special spatial structure that was only called a sea?

For some reason, Duncan suddenly thought of that girl named Shirley, and of her inseparable pet and weapon, “Dog”.

Dog was a “Abyssal Hound”. In the terms of this world, that was a kind of demon summoned from a depth of the Abyssal Deep into the Mortal Realm.

Duncan could not imagine what kind of internal structure such a skeletal hound might have. From its appearance, it clearly was not a “marine creature”… so it was not too bold to guess that this so-called “Abyssal Deep Sea” might not really be a “sea” at all.

It might be an extremely vast and strange space, and… it was wrapped in the Starry Sky.

As Duncan sketched a possible spatial model for the Abyssal Deep Sea in his mind, Morris noticed that the antique shopkeeper in front of him suddenly seemed a bit distracted. The old mister looked at Duncan with curiosity and asked: “Do you also study Astrology?”

“I just… have some interest,” Duncan tugged at the corner of his mouth. In his heart, he thought that after he had already accepted the fact that this world had no Starry Sky, hearing the word “Astrology” again all of a sudden felt very strange indeed. “The Starry Sky is hidden so deep… it cannot be easy to explore it.”

“That is, of course, extremely dangerous,” Morris said. “But thankfully, we can also observe projections of the Starry Sky through some indirect scientific methods. For that, we must thank technological progress. After the Spirit Realm lenses appeared, navigators on ocean-going vessels went mad much less often during navigation.”

Morris laughed. He seemed not to have found someone willing to discuss these questions with him for a long time, and he was in high spirits now. “You must know, a century ago, navigator was always the deadliest job on an ocean-going vessel… I have always wanted to collect a set of the earliest Spirit Realm lenses, but I really have no way to get any.”

Duncan blinked. He did not care at all what the old mister said last. He only felt that a question which had bothered him for a long time finally had an answer:

In a world whose sky had no celestial bodies, how did ships on long voyages calibrate their route?

The answer was that they still relied on stargazing—using special scientific instruments to observe projections of the Starry Sky reflected from the depths of the Spirit Realm.

Before New City-State Calendar 1800, navigating ships was even a deadly job.

After all, ordinary ships did not have the Vanished’s “enchanted sea chart”, which updated in real time like satellite positioning. They did not have a reliable goat First Mate either.

“You really are a very learned man,” after they had talked through many issues, Duncan finally could not help saying with real feeling, “Nina is very lucky to have a Teacher like you.”

“I am also very glad to see that she has an Uncle like you,” Morris nodded with reserved politeness. “Now all my doubts are gone. You are not only a responsible guardian, but you also have broad interests and a strong desire to learn. To be honest… it has been a very long time since I last talked so happily with someone.”

The old man spoke and gave a slight sigh. “My life now is good in every way—quiet, peaceful, free from many petty matters in the Upper City. The only problem is that most of the time it is hard to find anyone willing to listen to me talk about these dull things… Even the other Teachers I work with often cannot keep up with my train of thought. It is rare to find someone like you, who can listen to me talk this much.”

“I am happy to be your listener,” Duncan grinned at once when he heard that. “I have a special interest in history.”

“I can see that,” Morris, the old mister, smiled in satisfaction. Then he glanced toward the shop window, and only then did he realize how much time had passed. He hurried to his feet. “Oh, by the Goddess, I have already been here the whole afternoon?”

“If you do not mind, you could stay the night,” Duncan said offhandedly. “You can try my cooking.”

“…I should still be able to catch the bus back to the Crossroad District,” Morris looked at the slowly sinking Sun and politely declined Duncan’s kindness. “Thank you for the invitation, but I think I should go home. The city has not been very peaceful lately. If I stayed out all night, my family would worry.”

“That’s true… then I won’t insist,” Duncan thought for a moment and stood up to walk him out. “I’ll call Nina down first.”

Morris had just opened his mouth to speak when Duncan had already turned his head toward the second floor and called: “Nina! Mr. Morris is going home. Come down and see your Teacher off!”

Footsteps came from the stairs. Nina, now in a simple house dress, ran lightly down. She greeted her Teacher first, then glanced at the sky outside and looked at Duncan in surprise: “You two have been talking for this long?!”

“We had a very pleasant talk,” Morris said with a smile. “Your Uncle is a man with broad interests who enjoys learning. We discussed many questions about history.”

Duncan stood beside them with a serious face, nodding silently.

So-called “discussion” really meant that the old mister had talked on his own while Duncan pretended to understand and muddled through as he listened. But since the old mister himself put it that way, Duncan certainly would not say otherwise—and to be fair, he felt he had been a pretty good listener. He had asked questions at the right times so the conversation could keep going. For an old scholar who usually suffered from having no one to listen to his rambling, was that not the best kind of “discussion” there was?

Nina looked suspiciously from her Uncle to the smiling old mister. She wanted to say that her Uncle was not exactly known for broad interests and a love of study, but when the words reached her lips, she swallowed them back. Then she suddenly grew a little nervous, tugged on Duncan’s sleeve, and whispered: “Did you two talk about me?”

“Just a few little things from school,” Morris said. Though he was getting on in years, his hearing was excellent, and he immediately heard the girl’s whisper. “Your Uncle will tell you. Don’t worry, I did not complain about you.”

As he spoke, the old man picked up the Gatekeeper's cane he had left by the door when he came in. He also checked the old dagger tucked inside his coat. Only then did he say goodbye to the uncle and niece and slowly walk out the door.

After seeing the old mister off, Duncan looked at the sky outside, then simply hung up the "Closed" sign and locked the shop door. At this hour, he did not expect any more customers.

Besides, he had just earned a large sum. Ordinary "business" did not feel all that important anymore.

Nina watched Duncan bustle about—locking the door, tidying the counter. She felt full of questions. But before she could speak, Duncan suddenly looked up at her with a smile and said: "In a couple of days, I'll take you to buy a bicycle."

"Ah?" Nina froze for a second. "Why…?"

"I already got a bonus from City Hall before this, which was enough money," Duncan said, raising the bank check in his hand. "And just now I made a big sale. I think… we can afford to live a little better. At the very least, a bicycle would be very useful, don't you think?"

"A big sale…" Nina finally caught up. "Ah, you really sold that dagger to Mr. Morris?"

"I did," Duncan nodded. "I sold it for more than three thousand sola."

Nina: "…!?"

The girl, who had a very clear sense of money, was shocked by the number. Then she looked at her Uncle Duncan with a very strange expression.

"Teacher came for a home visit, and you kept him here talking all afternoon," she said. "Then you sold him something worth more than three

thousand sola… What will people think if this gets around later?”

Duncan thought for a moment, then said with a straight face: “Our shop will become famous?”

Nina: “Are you serious?”

Duncan spread his hands. “What else could I do? The old mister liked that piece. I couldn’t just give it to him for free. It’s rare for the shop to have something genuinely valuable.”

Nina put her hands on her hips, her cheeks puffing out. But in the end, the breath she had been holding suddenly turned into a smile.

Chapter 94: Nina’s Strange Dream

Outside, the sky over the street was slowly growing dark.

After seeing Morris off and tidying up the first-floor shop, Duncan finally had time to bring up what Nina’s teacher had said during the home visit.

After all, that had actually been the main reason Mr. Morris had come by today—though the two of them had ended up drifting off topic as they talked.

At the dining table on the second floor, Duncan was spreading butter on a slice of bread as he asked with concern: “Have you not been sleeping well lately? Or are you feeling unwell? I heard from your teacher that this has been going on for several days.”

Nina looked a little nervous. She had more or less guessed that her teacher would mention these things during the visit, but until very recently, she had never imagined that her uncle Duncan would really start paying attention to how she was doing at school.

A strange feeling spread through her heart. It had been a long time since anyone cared about her like this. She felt awkward and uneasy, but also faintly warmed.

“It’s just that I’ve been… really sleepy,” Nina said.

“So it seems what Mr. Morris said was true.” Duncan watched Nina’s face carefully. “Is it something with your health? Or something else? If you have anything on your mind, you can tell me.”

He paused for a moment, then added after thinking it over: “Of course, at your age there are probably things you don’t want to tell an adult like me, and that’s normal. You’re growing up, you have your own personality and your own thoughts, and all of that should be respected.

“But you still need to remember this: when people run into trouble, asking for help is nothing to be ashamed of. If it’s something I can help with, you can just say it. We’ll figure it out together.”

He tried his best to make his words sound steady and kind. That was not easy for him. He had never had a blood relative this age to take care of before. Still, he did have some experience dealing with students, so he simply talked to Nina the way he would talk to a teenager. In his opinion, his attitude was already gentle and reliable enough.

“I… I’m really fine, really!” Nina still was not used to such a kind uncle, but deep down she did not reject it. She waved her hands hard and met Duncan’s gaze. “It’s just that I’ve been feeling really sleepy lately. I keep waking up all of a sudden when I’m asleep, and sometimes I… dream.”

“Dream?” Duncan frowned and suddenly thought of something. “Nightmares? Do you dream about that big fire when you were little?”

Maybe because he had been focused recently on the fragments of the Sun and that eleven-year-old cold case, his thoughts went there at once. But Nina shook her head. “No, it’s not about when I was little.”

“Then what is it?”

“I keep dreaming that… that I’m standing somewhere very, very high. It feels like the tower of a building in the city. The streets below me are all pitch-black. Everywhere is ruins and ash,” Nina said slowly, trying to recall. “The ruins and ash are like a huge scar. It runs from the center of the Lower

City all the way to the Crossroad District, and then to the edge of the Upper City, like it's going to tear the whole city apart.

"I'm trapped in that very high place. I want to leave, but something like an invisible wall stops me…"

Nina thought for a moment, then shook her head lightly. "The dream is always like that. If you say it's scary… actually, nothing really scary shows up. No danger comes close to me. I just watch the city get crushed by something I can't see, and it leaves that scar. And I'm stuck there, unable to move. Every time I wake up I feel exhausted, and then I start nodding off in class the next day…"

Duncan listened carefully to the girl's description, and his frown deepened bit by bit.

What Nina described was definitely not the fire she had gone through in her childhood, nor was it anything in Duncan's own memories.

It sounded more like a static "display," showing her some scene from Pland in a time and place neither of them knew.

If this had been Earth, Duncan would only have treated it as a recurring odd dream. But in this strange world filled with Anomalies, he could not help feeling alarmed.

First there was Nina remembering a fire that seemed to exist only in her mind and Duncan's, and now there were these unending strange dreams that felt almost like a prophetic vision.

"When did these dreams start?" Duncan asked, his expression growing serious.

"About a week or two ago? Maybe earlier… I don't really remember," Nina said. She took a sip of vegetable soup, her voice a little muffled. "I didn't pay much attention at first…"

When Duncan heard that, he almost said, “You should have told someone earlier,” but then he suddenly remembered something. At that time, Nina’s “uncle” had still been a good-for-nothing, drowning himself in cult activities and alcohol.

Back then, she had not had any reliable person she could talk to at all.

He forced the words back down and changed what he was going to say: “Have you consulted any professionals? Like a doctor?”

Nina raised her head. “You mean… a psychiatrist?”

“Yes, a psychiatrist.” Duncan thought for a moment, then nodded at once.

In this world, psychiatrists were an indispensable profession. There were too many things lurking in the veil of night and the Deep Sea, watching the city-states with hungry eyes. The minds of ordinary people were easily affected by those whispers and breaths. Big and small problems would appear—nightmares, auditory hallucinations, visual hallucinations, Cognitive Shifts, even personality disorders.

These illnesses troubled many, many people, so treatment in this field had developed to an unbelievable level. The most skilled psychiatrists even used supernatural power to straighten out a twisted mind.

Nina’s constant strange dreams should also count as one of the “symptoms” psychiatrists watched for.

“I haven’t,” Nina muttered. “Their fees are really expensive… and I’m just having some weird dreams.”

“But those dreams have already started to affect your life,” Duncan said, his voice very firm. “Dreaming of such strange scenes again and again might be a sign of danger. You should have learned about things like this at school.”

As he spoke, his thoughts were racing. These repeated weird dreams of Nina's clearly had a problem. No matter what, since he was now living in a world full of strange Anomalies, he had to stay alert whenever elements from the supernatural realm showed up.

But he himself was an outsider when it came to theory. He would have to find some professionals to deal with this.

And it happened that he also wanted a chance to meet some "professionals" from civilized society, and see how they handled incidents that might involve the supernatural.

Nina still seemed hesitant, but in the face of Duncan's serious expression, she finally surrendered. "Then… then this weekend we can go to the community cathedral first and ask the Deep Sea priest there to give me a calming divine blessing. That doesn't cost much. If it doesn't work… then we can find a psychiatrist who specializes in this stuff. Is that okay?"

The cathedral? A priest of the Deep Sea? A priest who served the storm goddess Gamona?

Duncan's heart stirred. He felt that this was also a good idea—he had been wanting to meet those priests who served deities.

"All right, then it's settled," he nodded at once. "You're going to the City Museum this weekend anyway. When you come back, we'll stop by the cathedral."

"Mm!"

After dinner, Nina went back to her room early as usual. Duncan returned to his own room and at once saw AI's lazy form sprawled across the windowsill.

The pigeon had spent the whole day flying around outside and had come back with nothing to show for it.

Duncan closed the door behind him, then walked over to the window. When the pigeon saw its master, it lazily raised one wing in greeting and grumbled: “Let everything be destroyed already, I’m tired…”

“You really worked hard today.” Just one look at the half-dead bird told Duncan how exhausted it was. He stepped forward and unfastened the “cultist detector” strapped to the pigeon’s back while soothing it: “This job really isn’t easy. They’re all hiding very deep, and the Deep Sea Church has been watching closely lately. They’re bound to be even more careful…”

AI rolled its eyes, shook its wings once, and then lay flat again, not moving at all.

Duncan could not help laughing at that. “Even so, we still have to keep doing this… Of course, having you fly around all day might be a bit too much. I’ll arrange a better balance between work and rest for you.”

He had already decided to treat hunting cultists in the city as a long-term task.

After today’s “big job,” he was no longer under such urgent pressure for money. He did not need to rely on “hunting” to cover household expenses. But making trouble for those cultists was meaningful in itself.

On one hand, he might be able to fish out a big target from among them and use that to get the information he needed. Higher-ranking priests were sure to know more secrets about the Sun, and perhaps more details about the fragments that had appeared eleven years ago. Those were exactly what Duncan cared about most.

On the other hand, there was also that seemingly feral dog-eared supernatural girl active in the city-state. She was also constantly going after the Suntists. She might know certain secrets of the supernatural world.

Duncan wanted to try his luck and see if he could talk to her again about the Abyssal Deep Sea, and the demons of the Abyssal Deep.

After his talk with Morris, he was now intensely curious about that layer of “Starry Sky” hanging above the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea.

Noticing the serious look on Duncan’s face and sensing its future of forced overtime, AI let out an extremely human-like sigh.

“Ah…” The bird’s tone was full of sorrow. “A pitiful thick barrier has already come between us…”

“Your vocabulary is pretty impressive,” Duncan said.

Chapter 95: Infiltration

Another small group of Heretics of the Sun who had slipped in from Cold Harbor on smuggling boats had been dragged out and locked in the cathedral near the Harbor District.

Vanna came back from the dungeon beneath the cathedral and stepped into the lounge off the upper sanctuary. The regional Bishop in charge of this cathedral was already waiting in the room.

“Inquisitor Vanna,” the slightly thin Bishop greeted the young Inquisitor with a bow. “May the waves protect your soul.”

“May the waves protect your soul,” Vanna replied, then walked with somewhat tired steps toward a chair at the side. “In the Harbor District alone, this is already the second batch of Heretics of the Sun thrown into the cells, isn’t it?”

“Yes. Three days ago we caught more than a dozen,” the Bishop said with a nod, his eyes tinged with worry. “They were trying to kill a citizen when they were discovered and stopped in time. Now this is the second batch. They drew a meter reader’s suspicion while holding a dark ritual in an apartment building.

“We never realized that so many cultists had infiltrated…” He shook his head slightly. “Luckily we found them early. Otherwise, who knows how many people their dark rituals would have killed.”

“Pland is the main hub of the Boundless Sea, and everything has been calm for the last four years,” Vanna said with a nod. “That made many people’s

nerves go numb.

“But… we still don’t know if we discovered this early or late. Those Heretics who arrived ahead of time might have been active in the dark for a while already. They only exposed themselves recently.”

The Bishop glanced at Vanna’s face, hesitated for a moment, and then asked: “I heard other districts have caught quite a few as well?”

“Yes. Almost every district in the city-state,” Vanna answered without hiding anything. “Right now, the underground cells of almost every cathedral are holding captured Heretics of the Sun. Some cathedrals only have a few. Others have dozens.

“But most of them are just the lowest-level lackeys, moving around the city-state to gather information. They haven’t had much training, so they expose themselves easily.

“We still haven’t found any of the real upper-level priests.”

By the time she finished, even Vanna’s own tone had turned unconsciously grave. A faint uneasiness showed on her face.

Ever since the hunt for the Heretic cultists seeking the “fragments of the Sun” had begun, Pland’s authorities and the Church had reacted at once. They launched a sweeping hidden search all across the city and urged citizens everywhere to report suspicious behavior.

The results of this wave of action were impressive.

In a very short time, a large number of cultists who had not yet had time to react were exposed and captured. These bloodstained cultists now almost filled the underground prisons of the various cathedrals.

Their number was nearly equal to the total number of cultists discovered within the city-state over the last four years.

Yet up to this moment, all those arrested were only the ones running around at the bottom. At best, they included a few low-ranking priests carrying mass-produced sacred relics who had only just received a divine blessing.

The true high-level powers were still hiding in the shadows.

That was what made Vanna feel faintly irritated and uneasy.

“Every day we have results, but we still can’t grasp their ‘core,’” she said to the Bishop in front of her. “It gives me the feeling that the situation is still getting worse somewhere outside our sight.

“With so many cultists moving inside the city-state, there must be a high-level commander arranging everything behind them. But that commander still hasn’t shown up.”

The Bishop thought for a moment, then spoke slowly: “According to the interrogations so far, these lackeys only follow the orders of ‘Envoys.’ These so?called Envoys are a group of low-level priests. They use imitation masks of the Sun, and through a Listening Rite, they hear the voice of the spawn of the Sun directly…

“Do you think it’s possible that a spawn of the Sun has already slipped into the city-state and is hiding here?”

“A spawn of the Sun hiding in a human city-state? Honestly… that doesn’t quite fit with how things work,” Vanna said, frowning. “They might have great power, but they leave obvious traces behind. Their foul, filthy aura can’t be hidden.

“There are cathedrals and patrolling Guardian squads all over the city-state. In theory, there shouldn’t be any blind spots.”

“So it’s only a guess,” the Bishop said with a slight shake of his head. “I also know it’s very hard for a spawn of the Sun to hide in civilized society.

“But those low-level Envoys really do carry the masks of the Sun with them. Even if they are not directly controlled, they must be in contact with the spawn of the Sun to some degree.

“After all, mass-produced sacred relics are still sacred relics. Those cultists also have to think about the cost of their actions. They wouldn’t make arrangements that are totally meaningless.”

“I read yesterday’s interrogation records,” Vanna said, touching her fingers lightly to her chin as she thought. “Those Heretics are mainly asking about the supernatural incident that happened in the city-state eleven years ago…

“They think it has something to do with the fragments of the Sun?”

“That’s how it looks now.” The Bishop nodded. “We don’t know where their information came from, but they seem very sure that fragments of the Sun were what caused the ‘great chemical plant riot’ in Pland eleven years ago. I remember you were also…”

The Bishop suddenly stopped. His eyes fell on the striking scar around Vanna’s left eye, and he lowered his head slightly. “Forgive me. I spoke out of turn.”

Vanna lifted a hand without thinking and brushed her fingers over the scar on her face. Then she smiled calmly and shook her head. “It’s fine. It’s just a scar. You’re right, I was also there when that riot happened. There’s nothing that can’t be said about it.”

“There were cultists involved in that riot as well,” the Bishop said in a low voice. “Afterward, among the rioters who were arrested, more than a hundred were Heretics of the Sun.

“But now, the Heretics of the Sun who infiltrated the city-state are asking about the truth of what happened eleven years ago again… As if they really don’t know what happened here back then.

“Don’t you think that’s strange?”

“Either the Heretics of the Sun in Pland acted on their own eleven years ago, so the cultists in other city-states don’t know the truth here,” Vanna said quietly, “or… the appearance of fragments of the Sun in Pland eleven years ago was only an accident, or the work of some third party.

“The Heretics who took part in that riot were only being used as tools.”

She added calmly: “According to the interrogation records back then, the ‘rioters’ we captured were all in a confused state.

“Their frenzied runaway state didn’t look like it came from their own will. It looked more like they had been pushed into madness under the influence of some overwhelming power.”

“…They chased after twisted, eerie things, only to be ruled and driven mad by that eerie power,” the Bishop sighed. “In that dazed state, they became fuel for the fire of chaos, and in the end they were thrown aside in the ashes.

“It’s a truly pitiful kind of life.”

Vanna did not answer at once.

She simply stood up in silence and walked to the window of the lounge.

Through the glass, she could faintly see the Harbor District. The full lockdown there had already ended. Many of the piers and jetties had gone back into use. But Pier One was still under the highest level of lockdown.

That beautiful, brand-new steamship, the White Oak, still lay quietly at the end of the pier. As planned, it was under non?stop surveillance and underwent a purification ritual once every day.

The crew of the White Oak had been transferred to the central cathedral. As people who had made close contact with the Vanished, they were now under

the highest level of watch.

Heretics of the Black Sun were imprisoned in the dungeons under the cathedral. A “Homecoming Ship of the Lost” that had encountered the Vanished was moored in the harbor.

And a whole group of seafarers who had come face-to-face with Captain Duncan were staying inside the central cathedral…

Just thinking about it was enough to give someone a headache.

The sun was already sinking, though it was not yet time for day and night to trade places. The Bishop lit several oil lamps in the room ahead of time. The wavering flames were reflected faintly in the window glass.

Vanna withdrew her gaze from the Harbor District. “I heard the notice about Anomaly 099’s runaway state has already been sent to the Harbor District?”

“Yes. It was just delivered this afternoon. Would you like to look it over?” the Bishop said. As he spoke, he took a folded document from his robe. “It arrived a little later than we expected, for some reason.”

“Let me see it.”

Vanna reached out and took the document, then began to read it by the fading light at the window. At the same time, she explained casually: “Being a little late is normal. Anomaly 099’s runaway was very unusual. It broke out of its seal during direct contact with that ghost ship.

“The Bishops of each city-state had to think very carefully about the wording and implications in this notice, so that the information it points to stays under control.

“Otherwise, a document that’s supposed to help captains avoid risks on the sea might end up creating too many ‘connections’… and link them to the Vanished instead.”

In the dim light of the approaching sunset, the oil lamp closest to Vanna suddenly flickered.

As the word “Vanished” slipped out of her mouth without a thought, the flame inside the lamp gave a tiny crackling sound.

Chapter 96: gaze

Inside the captain’s cabin of the Vanished, Duncan was sitting by the window with his arms folded across his chest, eyes closed as he rested. He slowly opened his eyes.

He glanced around at the familiar furnishings of the room, checked the state of his body, and let out a small breath of relief.

Right now, he had once again shifted his main consciousness to the Vanished. The body left in the city-state of Pland remained in the antique shop. He was a bit rusty as he controlled that body to tidy the first-floor shop and hang the “Closed for the Evening” sign on the door.

In the captain’s cabin, Duncan slowly rose from the chair. As he flexed his arms and legs, he looked toward the nearby desk. He saw the pigeon AI strolling along the edge of the tabletop. The Sun mask he had sent here earlier still lay quietly on the desk. In the afterglow of the sunset pouring through the window, the mask’s golden surface shimmered with a trancelike sheen, as if illusory flames were flowing through its golden patterns.

In front of the antique shop, the Duncan there as shopkeeper finished hanging the wooden “Closed for the Evening” sign. He turned and greeted a neighbor who happened to be on the way home. With a faint smile, he chatted with this “old neighbor” about today’s weather and how business had been lately.

His expression in front of the antique shop looked a little stiff, and his speech was somewhat slow, but the neighbor did not grow suspicious. A

useless gambler who had been drowning in alcohol not long ago was now actually living seriously—that alone was shocking enough. Compared to that, a slightly sluggish reaction was nothing. How energetic could a body ruined by alcohol be, anyway?

Back in the captain's cabin, a faint smile appeared on Duncan's face. After using his "remote interaction shell" to complete a first attempt at socializing, he casually picked up the Sun mask lying on the desk.

There was still much to do in the city-state of Pland, but not everything could be done overnight. The city-state had strict curfew rules after nightfall. At night it was better for his human body to stay obediently in the shop so as not to draw attention. The hours after dusk were best left to the "true body" on the Vanished.

He planned to use this time to study the mask he had taken from that Sun priest.

The mask felt icy cold in his hand, as if cast entirely from metal. It was heavy, with real weight.

Looking at the golden object in his hand, Duncan's thoughts suddenly grew lively. The first thing he wondered was whether this thing was pure gold. If it was, then after he finished studying it, melting it down might fetch a lot of money…

For now he had no financial pressure in the city-state, but money was something one could never have too much of in human society. What if he needed it later?

There were many ways to fleece those Suntists. He could squeeze information out of them, turn them in for bounties, or get supernatural items that suited him. If there were extra supernatural items he did not need, it was perfectly normal to do a little processing and sell them off.

This was called multi-directional development and sustainable wool-gathering.

He thought it over for a moment, then rubbed his chin and sighed with feeling: “Every part of a Suntist is a treasure…”

AI, who had been strolling around, suddenly stopped. She tilted her head at Duncan and let out a sharp female voice: “Have some humanity, would you! Have some humanity!”

“You, a bird, have no right to say that to me.” Duncan glared at the pigeon, then rubbed his fingertips together, ready to summon the spirit form flame. He would first “clean” the mask from inside to outside, and after he controlled its permissions, he would carry out a deeper “test”.

A wisp of faint green flame burned at his fingertips. Duncan was about to channel the fire into the mask when he suddenly heard a vague voice. The sound was weak and hazy, as if whispering in the depths of his heart:

“…it might instead connect them to the Vanished…”

Duncan’s movements stopped at once.

He looked at the pigeon beside him and asked: “Did you hear a voice just now?”

The pigeon thought for a moment, then flapped her wings and began to sing loudly, hopelessly off-key: “Hear~ the sound of the sea crying~ lamenting whose heart has been hurt again~”

“Stop, stop, stop… I should never have asked you!” Duncan hurriedly pressed the pigeon down. In his heart he complained that talking with this bird was like a quantum state—nothing said or heard ever lined up. After holding the pigeon still, he focused his mind at once, trying to trace the brief sensation that had stirred in his heart when that “whisper” sounded.

He was sure he had not imagined it. He was sure he had heard a voice just now, a young and calm female voice.

At the same time the voice sounded, he had vaguely sensed a kind of “connection”. It was much weaker than the link between him and his remote body, but it definitely existed.

Duncan temporarily put the matter of the Golden Sun Mask aside and glanced again at the spirit form flame still burning quietly at his fingertips.

That faint connection also seemed to be based on the burning of the fire.

He closed his eyes slightly, feeling the “sense of direction” the flame gave him. In the darkness that followed, he seemed to see a glimmer of light appear before his eyes.

That faint light was vaguely like a “window”. There seemed to be a figure moving inside it, but he could not see clearly or hear what was happening on the other side.

Even so, Duncan still sensed the flame’s guidance in the unseen. He opened his eyes and searched in the direction where the light had appeared in the darkness. Suddenly he saw a mirror hanging beside the cabin door.

It was just an ordinary oval scrying mirror with a simple, dark wooden frame. It was not an supernatural item, no different from what many regular households used.

But Duncan could feel that his flame now needed a medium to strengthen this suddenly formed, weak link. Thinking of the blurry scene he had seen in the dark and the faint sense of its direction, a mirror seemed very suitable.

In many occult studies rituals, mirrors held an important place. They were seen as symbols of “insight” and could be used to extend the mind’s perception, to observe truths that were originally invisible and unknowable.

Duncan walked up to the mirror and casually touched the surface with the flame in his hand.

The green spirit form flame flowed like water, rippling across the glass surface. A film of light, faintly glowing green, formed a channel in an instant. In the next second, the glimmering window he had seen in the darkness appeared crystal clear on the mirror!

He leaned in curiously.

Within the faintly rippling curtain of light, he saw a room lit by lamps. A tall, unusually large young lady stood near the window, using the last light of day to read something. She seemed completely unaware that a gaze was peering through the glass beside her, watching the scene inside the room.

Vanna’s eyes moved across the document, checking every word and sentence.

This notice had been drawn up through joint discussion by bishops from all the city-states and personally reviewed and approved by His Eminence the Pope, who presided over the great Storm Cathedral. The discussion and drafting of the notice had been completed remotely in a state of Psychic Resonance, under the Goddess’s gaze and protection throughout, to ensure that no Anomaly or Vision interfered with the wording during the process.

These very special notice documents had only one purpose: to inform every long-distance voyager sailing on the Boundless Sea that a high-ranked Anomalous item had broken away from the control of the civilized world.

This was necessary.

On the Boundless Sea, Anomalous items that entered a runaway state did not disappear from the world forever. The Deep Sea devoured everything, yet never devoured the “Anomalies” that fell into it. Those that slipped free of control often wandered along the edges of the civilized world in even

stranger, harder-to-guard-against ways, like packs of wolves roaming around a pasture, chasing and threatening the safety of voyagers. Almost every year, long-distance seafarers died after encountering runaway state Anomalies.

As guardians and sealers of Anomalous items, each Church had to inform all captains who might encounter them whenever an Anomalous item under its name entered a runaway state. No one saw this as hurting the Holy See's "face", because it was the Church's duty and obligation.

Sending out timely notices about runaway states might one day save an unlucky ship that ran into an Anomaly, or make it possible to re?seal and contain a runaway state Anomalous item.

Normally such notices reached Harbor offices within twenty?four hours of a runaway state incident. But this notice about "Anomaly 099" was a little late.

Because this runaway state incident involved not only Anomaly 099 – doll spirit coffin, but also Visions 005 – the Vanished.

The Pope and the bishops had to weigh every word in the document carefully, to make sure the information disclosed was accurate, yet also avoid drawing the attention of the Vanished when people read it.

Vanna's face was as calm and dark as still water. She read the document word by word, checking that the phrasing followed the sacred, unseen structure of prayer and could avoid the gaze of that ghost captain on the Vanished.

And on the window glass beside her, in a seam of light and shadow neither she nor the regional bishop could perceive, Duncan was craning his neck, trying hard to peek at the document's contents.

[ghost captain, deeply shocked.jpg.]

Chapter 97: Who Is Drafting the List?

The view shown in the mirror seemed to be based on a window. Duncan felt like someone pressed right up against the panes, peering through the glass at the room inside. In the room, there was a tall, unusually large young woman. Her side profile looked somewhat familiar.

After thinking for a moment, Duncan remembered where he had seen that face. This was the widely respected inquisitor from Pland, Vanna Wayne!

Her figure had appeared in the newspapers.

Why was he seeing this scene? Why was he suddenly looking through a window at this believer of the Storm Goddess? Was there some hidden connection? When had this connection formed? Why had he never noticed it before, yet now suddenly sensed this invisible “thread”?

Countless thoughts flashed through Duncan’s mind, but in the next second, the jumble in his head was cut off by something his gaze swept across.

He saw clearly what the inquisitor in the mirror, Miss Vanna, was reading.

It was a document written in a strict format, the paper stamped with the holy symbol of the Storm Goddess. The very first line read: To all captains on the Boundless Sea and their accompanying priests and guides, Anomaly 099 – doll spirit coffin has recently entered a runaway state. Witnessed by the Most Holy and All-Seeing, the cursed item has been lost in the storm.

The runaway state of this Anomaly and its traits are hereby announced as follows…

Duncan's eyes slowly widened. His gaze went past Vanna's shoulder. The document described Anomaly 099 in wording that read like a specific kind of prayer. He saw mention of a dangerous curse with the power of decapitation, saw the origin of the doll spirit coffin, and saw records related to "Alice Guillotine"…

In his shock, his gaze slid downward. Near the end of the document he saw a record of the White Oak being "attacked". However, the key part of the last sentence was blocked by the inquisitor's tall figure, and he could not see it no matter how he tried.

Duncan leaned left and right in front of the mirror, anxious, and muttered without thinking: "Move a bit, move a bit to the side…"

In the lounge, Vanna suddenly felt as if a strand of breeze brushed past her earlobe. She turned her head reflexively and saw that the window was open a crack. The cold sea wind of evening was blowing in.

The flames of several oil lamps in the room wavered. Their soft light drove away the malice that spread through the world as the veil of night approached, and brought her a special sense of peace.

She set the document aside and turned to the regional bishop: "Put it away. The bishops of the city-states must have made thorough arrangements. This is very safe."

The regional bishop nodded, stepped forward to collect the document, and turned up the electric light in the room. Its brightness drove away the gloom of the changing day and night even more than the oil lamps. "Will you have to hurry back to the central Cathedral tonight?"

“Valentine Bishop is still waiting to discuss matters with me,” Vanna nodded slightly. “Things have been unsettled in the city-state recently. We may need to carry out a large-scale benediction to strengthen the Cathedral’s protection over the entire city-state.”

As she spoke, she looked up at the chandelier hanging from the ceiling. The electric bulbs in it made the room as bright as daytime. “…If only electric lights could ward off evil,” she said. “They’re so bright, and their range is much wider than fire…”

“Who doesn’t think so?” The regional bishop spread his hands. “It’s a pity that electricity has no sanctity.”

Vanna shook her head and said nothing more. After bidding the regional bishop farewell, she walked out of the lounge.

After Vanna left, one oil lamp near the window suddenly flickered a little, then quickly grew steady again.

The scene in the mirror slowly faded. When the green film of light vanished, the glass once again reflected the captain’s cabin.

Just now, when the inquisitor, Miss Vanna, had turned her head, Duncan had finally seen the last line of the document. For him, the most useful information in that line was just a few words:

Visions 005 – the Vanished.

“So the classification of the Vanished really is ‘Visions’… and the number is actually that high.” He returned to the desk, muttering thoughtfully, but then grew puzzled. “But then again, how are these numbers arranged?”

Nina’s textbooks had mentioned many Anomalies and Visions by number and name. They also mentioned this “list” and said the rules behind it came from the ancient Critt Kingdom. But they were vague about how the numbers for those Anomalies and Visions were set and who decided them.

They only said that each Church had the right to interpret and the duty to publish, and that under normal circumstances, the earlier an Anomaly or Vision was on the list, the stranger, more dangerous, or more historically significant it was. At first Duncan had not thought much about it, but now a doubt suddenly rose in his mind.

Were these numbers arranged in the order of discovery?

If it was by order of discovery, then the Vanished, which had only a history of a hundred years, could never hold such a high number. There were plenty of Visions older than the Vanished in this world. In theory, all the high-rank designations should have been filled long ago.

But if they were not ordered by discovery, and instead sorted by level of danger, then wouldn't the numbers have to change all the time? Every time a new Anomaly or Vision was found, they would have to reassess its danger, then adjust the entire "ranking list". That would become a huge project, and very awkward to use.

Although the textbooks said that the danger level of Anomalies and Visions did not always match their ranking one hundred percent, they also clearly stated that in most cases, those with earlier numbers were more terrifying and dangerous than those behind them.

That raised a question worth thinking about: if the current list of Anomalies and Visions was fairly stable and rarely changed, then whoever arranged it was almost like a prophet. When making the list, that person would have had to foresee the "rank" of every Anomaly and Vision, not only assigning accurate numbers when new ones were discovered, but also leaving "empty slots" in advance for powerful Anomalies and Visions that would appear in the future.

Because of the wording "Visions 005 – the Vanished", Duncan had suddenly felt puzzled by this "list" and the person behind it. But soon he set

those doubts aside for now.

Because at the moment, something was more important than the rules behind this “supernatural items ranking”—Alice.

That cursed doll from the Harmonious Church actually had such a big background!

“I’m going out for a bit.”

Duncan tossed the words casually to the pigeon on the desk and strode out of the captain’s cabin.

Goathead in the enchanted sea chart room heard the cabin door move and turned his head with a creak. When he saw Duncan, he greeted him out of habit: “Surname…”

“Duncan Abnomar—skip that part. Where is Alice?”

“Ah, great cap…” Goathead finished confirming the name and had just started his usual long speech when the captain cut him off. His neck creaked with the words stuck in his throat before he finally reacted. “You’re looking for Miss Alice? She might be in her room counting her hairs…”

“Counting her hairs?” Duncan froze. “What new problem has she picked up this time… Forget it, I’ll go myself. You just keep steering the ship.”

After saying this, he did not wait for a response. He turned and left the cabin in a hurry, leaving Goathead atop the enchanted sea chart table, staring blankly at the door that had already shut again.

“I didn’t even get a chance to say more…” After holding it in for a long while, Goathead finally reacted, sounding terribly depressed. “Has my ability to start a conversation gotten worse?”

As soon as he finished speaking, the door in the corner that led to the captain’s cabin opened a crack. The pigeon AI squeezed through with great

swagger and flapped to the table.

“Want five coins’ worth of chat?” the pigeon asked, tilting her head and blinking her little eyes.

“Sure, sure, as long as someone will chat with me!” Goathead brightened at once. Since everyone on the ship counted as “his own people”, he was not picky about his conversation partner at all. “What do you want to talk about? By the way, can you actually talk normally? I always feel you…”

“Get some fries.”

“Huh?” Goathead froze. “No, I mean, are you really aware that you…”

“Get some fries.”

“…If what you want to talk about is sea cuisine…”

“Get some fries.”

“Can you say anything else?”

“Get some fries.”

Goathead: “…”

Duncan paid no attention to what happened in the captain’s cabin after he left. He walked straight across the upper deck and soon reached the seafarers’ quarters below. After taking a moment in front of Alice’s door to sort out his thoughts, he knocked and said: “Alice, it’s me.”

A stammering voice came quickly from inside: “P-please… p-please… come in…”

Hearing that, Duncan raised his eyebrows without thinking and pushed the door open.

The doll in the long Brother-style robe sat at the table by the bed, facing a dressing mirror on the desk. She held her own head in both hands, silver-white hair cascading like a waterfall. The head turned its gaze toward him, and a pretty, delicate face slowly broke into a smile. “C-cap… cap… captain, g-g-good eve… eve… evening…”

Duncan said: “Put your head back on.”

“Pop.”

Chapter 98: Alice Knew Nothing

Imagine this scene: you were on a creaking ghost ship. You pushed open a wooden door at the deepest end of the corridor. A dim oil lamp swayed gently. In the flickering light, a headless doll in a Brother's long dress sat in front of a dressing mirror. The doll held her own head in her hands. The head turned toward you and slowly showed a stiff smile…

Duncan felt that if he had not already been on this ship for so many days, and if he were not already so familiar with Alice, he would have already taken an instant step forward and drawn his gun by now.

Alice, however, had no idea how creepy she had just made things. She obediently pressed her head back onto her neck with a soft pop. Her reactions became quick and lively again. She smiled brightly and greeted Duncan: "Good evening, Captain! Were you looking for me?"

Duncan finally pulled himself together. He looked this doll up and down suspiciously for a long moment and asked: "What are you doing here? Why did Goathead say you were in the cabin counting hairs?"

Alice rolled her neck left and right, then used her fingers to smooth her slightly messy hair. Her expression looked a bit embarrassed: "I was just… checking how much hair I had left."

Duncan stared at the doll as if he were looking at an idiot. Then he finally noticed something on the edge of the table. It was a spool from who knew where, with a few strands of silvery white hair wound around it. The source of those hairs was obvious…

Duncan kept a blank face: “…”

Alice noticed the captain’s gaze at once. She picked up the spool and explained to Duncan very seriously: “Look, this one is called Miffy, this one is Polly, this one is Femia, and this one, its name is…”

Duncan finally was shocked: “You even gave every hair that fell from your head a name?!”

“To keep a memento,” Alice said with a solemn look, with a bit of sorrow hidden in it. “Didn’t you say it yourself? I’m a doll, and dolls don’t grow hair on their own… If one day it all falls out, I can still hold the list and remember the wonderful times I spent with them…”

This doll left Duncan a bit dazed. He even forgot for a moment why he had come here. After staring in silence for a long time, he finally forced out a sentence: “I was only making an offhand remark back then. You didn’t need to take it to heart… No wonder you’ve been staying in the cabin these past two days. So you’ve been doing this every day? Counting hairs and naming each one that falls out?”

Alice nodded in the most harmless way: “Mm-hm.”

Duncan kept his face stiff. After a while he sighed and said: “Fine. Later I’ll look around in the city-states and see if there is any artificer who specializes in this field and can help you…”

Alice gasped: “You’re going to tie someone up and bring them onto the ship?”

Duncan glared at her: “…I’ll buy you a few wigs as backups! How could it make sense for the Boundless Sea’s mobile calamity to run to a human city-state to kidnap a dollmaker?”

“Well, a mobile calamity sneaking into a human city-state to buy wigs doesn’t sound very right either…” Alice muttered without thinking, but she

swallowed the rest of her words halfway through. “Ah, I’ll stop talking, heh heh…”

“Don’t just giggle foolishly,” Duncan suddenly felt a wave of exhaustion. He waved his hand and said: “Forget it, you distracted me so much I almost forgot business—Alice, sit down. I came to you for something serious.”

When Alice saw the captain’s serious expression, she knew it was no time for jokes. She quickly put away her ingratiating smile. While she gathered up the spool, she hurried to sit on the wooden chest by the bed. Her back was straight, her hands folded on her knees, every bit the picture of elegance and poise.

Duncan sighed. For some reason, his composure always broke easily in front of Alice. Even when he had first come to this world, he had stayed cold and calm in front of Goathead. Even when he had possessed the body of a sacrificial victim with his chest cut open and faced a floor full of remains, he had kept his expression steady. Only when facing this unnervingly weird doll did his expression and aura hover between breaking and not quite breaking.

Thinking it over, this was probably the power of “style.” The style that Alice brought really made it hard for anyone to keep a straight face.

He crooked a finger to the side. A chair in the room creaked and scooted over behind him at once. He sat down on it, trying to force his expression back to gloomy majesty, and fixed his gaze on Alice’s eyes.

“Ray Nora. Does that name mean anything to you?”

“Ray Nora?” Alice blinked. Her face showed pure confusion. “Never heard of her… She sounds like a woman? And it feels very elegant and noble… Is she an acquaintance of yours?”

“In theory, she should be someone ‘you’ know, but you say you don’t… Fine, I believe you.” Duncan was not very surprised by Alice’s answer. He went on: “Then what about the city-state of Frostholm? Are you familiar with it? Does it leave any impression on you?”

“Frostholm city-state?” Alice thought for a moment. “I heard about it when I was in the box. It seems to be a city-state on the Frost Sea. There is also a place called Cold Harbor, a gateway between Frostholm and the Central Seas. But I don’t know the details. I only ever heard the names.”

“Then what about ‘Alice Guillotine’?”

The doll looked completely puzzled: “I know Alice, that’s my name—but what is a guillotine?”

Duncan asked several more questions in a row, and the answers he got were all more or less the same.

This result was basically within his expectations.

Alice was utterly in the dark about all of this. Just as she had said on the first day they met, she had no idea about her own past. She did not know the truth behind “Anomaly 099,” she had never understood that city-state of Frostholm, and she had never even heard of the Frostholm Queen who had died half a century ago.

Even though her face was exactly the same as that Frostholm Queen’s.

Duncan had not expected many direct answers when he asked these questions. He only wanted to test whether Alice would have any special reaction when she heard these “key words.” Now the test was over, and the doll was still the same simple-minded doll as before.

He believed that this timid doll would not dare fake her real reactions in front of him—and her level of intelligence probably did not support such advanced tricks anyway.

So… perhaps what he should focus on was not the doll, but the “spirit coffin”?

Duncan’s gaze slowly sharpened. His attention fell on Alice’s ornate, heavy wooden chest.

That ornate chest, once used to contain the doll, still sat in the room, and Alice was sitting steadily on top of it now.

Alice liked her chest very much. She used it as a stool and a storage box, and sometimes even slept inside it—though the room had a perfectly normal bed.

“Open the chest and let me see,” Duncan said.

Alice felt a bit puzzled, but she still quickly hopped down from the chest and casually opened it.

Duncan stepped forward to look.

Inside, the chest was lined with soft red velvet. In one corner lay a small pile of odds and ends: a comb, a spool wrapped with hair, a pocket mirror, and several small metal trinkets.

“I found them on the ship, in other cabins,” Alice said carefully, pointing at the clutter in the corner of the chest. “I asked Mr. Goathead. He said these were ownerless things. I… can I keep them? I think they are very pretty…”

Duncan looked at those old ornaments.

Perhaps, a century ago, someone on this ship had worn them at the tips of their hair or on their chest.

They were traces from when the Vanished had still belonged to the Mortal Realm.

“They’re yours. Keep them,” Duncan said with a nod. But then his gaze suddenly caught on a small object in the pile of clutter. He could not help reaching out to pick it up. “This thing…”

It was a small hair clip, so delicate it did not seem like something that should appear on the Vanished. It looked like a silver-white feather, with tiny breaking waves carved along the edge. Though a century had passed, it was still as bright as new—completely different from those old items.

Duncan frowned. For some reason, when he saw this hair clip, a faint feeling of… longing rose in his heart.

There was even a name that almost slipped from his lips.

But he still could not remember what that almost-spoken name was.

Duncan blinked, a bit bewildered, not knowing where this sudden feeling from deep inside had come from. But gradually, he understood.

Just as, the moment he came onto this ship, he had known the name “Duncan Abnomar”… just now he had once again touched the “echo” still remaining in this body!

He lowered his head to look at the hair clip in his hand, wondering how such a delicate, tiny thing could resonate with the greatest calamity on the Boundless Sea. But soon, Alice’s voice jolted him out of his thoughts: “Captain? Captain, you…”

“Sorry, I can’t give you this hair clip,” Duncan came back to himself and said to Alice. Then he felt that sounded a bit too cold toward the doll miss, so he added: “When I get a chance later, I’ll buy you some new ones in the city-states—these things are all old anyway.”

“Really?!” Alice’s face lit up with delight. “Captain, you’re so nice!”

“Don’t praise me yet,” Duncan shook his head and casually put the hair clip away. “I haven’t finished the serious business… Alice, I’m going to tell you some things now, about your ‘true nature.’ You need to listen carefully.”

Chapter 99: The First Step of Testing and Control

After confirming that Alice had no reaction to any of the “key words,” and knew nothing about the ability called “Decapitation,” Duncan decided to tell this muddle-headed cursed doll what he had just learned.

By now he already had a vague guess. Perhaps the key to the anomaly Anomaly 099 – Doll spirit coffin was not Alice the doll herself… but her “spirit coffin.”

The wind and waves on the Boundless Sea were gentle. The cabin swayed softly with the swell. In the flickering light of the oil lamp, the ghost ship’s captain slowly told the past and present of the doll’s spirit coffin—and almost scared the doll into curling up into a ball.

Duncan, expressionless, looked at Alice, who was now sitting in the corner of the bed, back against the wall, clutching her head: “Did you really need to get this nervous?”

“Th-this… this really sounds terrifying!” Alice’s tone had changed. She sounded like an ordinary young lady who had just listened to a ghost story. “All that talk about indiscriminate Decapitation, and about only stopping after everything in range is dead, and about constantly expanding its territory… Th-this… I didn’t know any of that!”

“I do believe now that you really didn’t know,” Duncan glanced at Alice. “But this is indeed the information on Anomaly 099 – Doll spirit coffin.”

Alice held her head, her neck stiff as she looked at Duncan: “Then…”

“So I have two guesses now,” Duncan said. “First, those ‘Decapitation’ incidents might be an ability you activated unconsciously. You yourself are an anomaly, and your power is very likely just a passive area effect. Even in your previous ‘asleep’ state, it would not have stopped the Decapitation effect from occurring.”

As Duncan spoke, he slowly rose from his chair. He walked to the ornate wooden chest and tapped it with the tip of the long sword in his hand.

“Second, the ‘Decapitation’ power of the Doll spirit coffin might not come from you, the doll, but from your ‘spirit coffin’.”

“spirit coffin… you mean my chest?” Alice’s eyes slowly widened. Her gaze followed Duncan’s movement and fell on the wooden chest by the bed. The slow-on-the-uptake doll finally seemed to catch on: “You mean…”

“The full name of Anomaly 099 is ‘Doll spirit coffin’… In other words, you and your chest together make up the complete ‘Anomaly 099.’ When I first saw you, I subconsciously assumed you were the ‘main part’ of it… because I didn’t yet know the full name ‘Doll spirit coffin’,” Duncan rubbed his chin as he thought aloud. “Now that I think it over, the word ‘Doll spirit coffin’ itself… its emphasis seems to be on the latter half.”

Alice blinked. Her mind worked hard for a while, then she clapped her hands: “Oh! I’m the accessory that comes with the chest!”

Duncan gave the empty-headed doll a blank look: “…You don’t have to sound so proud when you say that.”

Alice seemed not to hear the mockery in Duncan’s tone. She only gave her wooden chest a troubled look and spoke in a slightly worried voice: “So that means… my chest has been ‘Decapitating’ people all along? But I’ve

lived in it for so long and never felt it was so evil and dangerous… and I've never felt it had any special power…"

"Nonsense. You're part of Anomaly 099 yourself. How could your feelings be any reference?" Duncan frowned. "And feel your own neck. I seriously suspect the reason your head falls off every now and then is because you've slept in that chest for too long!"

Alice instantly felt the captain had a point, and her expression became complicated at once. But then she grew confused again: "But if that's true… if 'Decapitation' is an inherent property of my spirit coffin, it has been on the ship for so long. Why haven't we seen its power activate?"

As soon as she finished speaking, she met Duncan's quiet gaze. The slow-reacting doll miss suddenly felt a wordless pressure crash down on her head—she had grown lax after living on the ship for a while, and only now suddenly remembered what kind of person this captain was.

Duncan simply gazed at the doll in silence. Only after Alice had curled herself into an even smaller ball did he speak in a low voice: "The only humanoid creature on this ship besides you is me. So what you mean is…"

"I don't mean anything!" Alice almost jumped up. She waved her hands frantically as she spoke: "Please listen to my excuse—I mean the chest…"

"I never said I was going to do anything to you," Duncan looked at her helplessly. "You're now a crew member of the Vanished, and I'm your protector on the Boundless Sea. You really don't have to be this afraid—can you sit properly? It makes it look like I'm bullying you."

Only then did Alice let out an "oh" and slowly scoot back to the edge of the bed. But because of her interruption, other thoughts rose in Duncan's heart. Yes, no matter whether the main body of the Doll spirit coffin was the doll or the spirit coffin, Anomaly 099 had stayed on the Vanished for so long

that it had long exceeded the interval for each of its “checks.” Yet this anomaly had always remained harmless… Obviously, it was being suppressed.

Then what was suppressing it—the Vanished, or himself, the “captain”?

Duncan lowered his head and looked at his own hands.

He knew he held rather great power. That power not only allowed him to completely take over the life of a cultist named “Ron,” but was so strong and strange that it made an upper-level anomaly like Alice tremble at first sight, and made “Ah Gou,” a demon of the Abyssal Deep, tuck his tail. He still did not know the essence of this power, but that did not stop him from slowly recognizing how special he was.

On the other hand, the Vanished itself was the fifth-ranked Vision on the Boundless Sea—“Vision,” not anomaly.

That meant that as long as something was within the Vanished’s range, there was a “field” working around the clock, constantly exerting influence on everything inside it.

With both captain and ship suppressing it, Anomaly 099 naturally stayed harmless. But if he really followed his plan and brought Alice to the city-state of Pland… then things could very easily slip out of control.

So he had to figure out a whole series of things—Was the body that produced Anomaly 099’s effects Alice the doll, or this wooden chest? Was it he, the captain, suppressing Anomaly 099, or was it the Vanished? If Alice and the chest were separated, would Anomaly 099’s effect still appear? If it was he, the captain, who created the suppression, what was the range of that suppression?

His thoughts spread further—

If it was the “spirit coffin” that produced the Decapitation effect, would it be safe to bring only Alice herself to Pland? If the spirit coffin was an anomaly component that could be separated out, could his flames also affect it alone? If he used fire to completely dominate this chest, would that be equivalent to controlling the formerly uncontrolled Decapitation effect—just like he used fire to control AI and the brass spirit compass?

A pile of questions lined up in Duncan’s mind, and these questions gradually formed a complex plan for comparative tests. But at the end of that plan, he found one discouraging fact:

He lacked many of the necessary conditions to run those tests.

The Vanished was not a proper testing ground, because the ghost ship’s power would interfere with the accuracy of the results. He also had no suitable test subjects—because Anomaly 099’s Decapitation effect was very costly in terms of lives… it burned through the “testers’” lives.

Duncan lifted his head and looked at Alice, who was sitting obediently at the bedside—the doll miss was gazing at her beloved chest with some sadness, all her tangled feelings practically written on her face.

Perhaps noticing the captain’s gaze, Alice suddenly broke the silence. She spoke softly: “From the day I became conscious… I’ve always lived in this chest. It is my bed, my home, and my Sanctuary World. When I sleep inside it, I feel very safe.”

Duncan did not speak. He only quietly looked at the doll before him.

“Now I know why those humans were so afraid,” Alice reached out and gently stroked her wooden chest. “What they feared was ‘us.’”

“I had originally planned to bring you to the city-state of Pland on my next walk in the Spirit Realm,” Duncan said in a low voice. “I need a helper over there.”

Alice’s eyes seemed to light up, but they dimmed again at once: “Ah, that might not be very good…”

“The plan is postponed, not canceled,” Duncan said, his expression and tone not changing much. “We just need more time to confirm your… ‘your group’s’ power and grasp the conditions under which this ‘Decapitation’ effect takes hold. The human city-states on land can already use various clever methods to seal or even make use of many anomalies. And this is the Vanished. There is even more we can do here.”

Alice gave Duncan a puzzled look. From the captain’s calm, deep gaze, she realized this was not just empty comfort.

“You have a plan?”

Duncan thought for a moment, then raised his fingertip and lit a faint ghostly flame.

“First, we might need a little fire.”

Chapter 100: Illusion and Reality in History

“Captain, are you sure this is really okay?” Alice watched the “little flame” in Duncan’s hand with deep worry. Both her hands kept tugging at the lace on the hem of her dress. “Don’t burn my house down…”

Duncan held a cluster of spirit form fire in his palm. While he searched for a place to start on Alice’s spirit coffin, he glanced back at the Doll with a helpless look and said: “My spirit form fire is completely under control—do you not trust my power?”

As soon as Alice heard that, she started waving her hands: “I do, I do…”

Only then did Duncan look away and steady himself.

With the current conditions on the Vanished, it was almost impossible to run a full set of tests on Alice’s spirit coffin. But that did not mean he could not at least do some “preliminary research”. Now that he had grown more and more skilled at controlling the spirit form fire, he had faintly grasped a way to use this flame to probe the inner secrets of supernatural objects.

He still did not dare use this flame on Alice’s body. But if it was only to study her wooden box… that was another story.

After making some preparations, Duncan finally reached out his hand and stretched the little flame at his fingertip toward the surface of the ornate wooden box.

The flame sank into the box in silence, like an unreal reflection. Alice stared with wide eyes, watching every tiny change in front of her. After two or three seconds of stillness, she saw phantom-like light spread through her field of vision—

The spirit form fire started to burn on the box, burning from the inside out! In the blink of an eye, the whole box took on a half-transparent look. In this strange, half-real scene, the blazing flames raced through every detail inside the box, as if they were rebuilding its “skeleton”!

“Hey, Captain, Captain, it’s on fire, it’s on fire!”

The Doll cried out in panic, but her shouting got no answer. Duncan had already put all his focus into controlling the flame and sensing the spirit coffin. With a solemn expression, he fixed his gaze on the dancing fire and the unreal wooden box in front of him. Alice’s voice in his ears sounded faint and distant, as if it came from another world.

Duncan’s mind slowly calmed down. He felt the world around him grow quieter and quieter. Even the endless wind and waves of the Boundless Sea seemed to drift far from his senses. He felt his power seep into a vast “place”, and more and more “perceptions” flowed into his mind through the channel the flame had opened—

This feeling was completely different from when he had used the fire to reshape the Sun charm amulet before!

If he had to compare, using the flame on the Sun charm amulet had felt as easy as filling a cup of water. But now he felt his fire surging nonstop into a great lake. The sizes were not on the same level at all.

So this was the gap between mass-produced supernatural items and an Anomaly ranked 099?

Understanding flashed through Duncan’s heart. In that instant, he suddenly felt the connection through the flame reach a peak. The flow of power became as smooth as a river. Right after that, a flood of “memories” rushed into his mind!

The sound of waves… Waves crashing on a strange shore. A cold wind blowing past tall walls. Massive walls stood in the distance, dim and blurry as if frozen in ice. And people… a swaying, dark crowd where he could only see outlines…

Duncan’s view floated at some point in the air, about two or three meters above the ground. He looked around in shock, but saw only an unfamiliar city-state and a high platform on the shore. Around the platform gathered countless black shapes. They looked like a crowd of people, vague and flickering, but he could not see a single face clearly.

A loud droning hum came from every direction. It sounded like people whispering and talking, yet it was strangely loud and noisy. Duncan tried to pick out the words. In the end he found it was not people talking at all, but countless “voices of the heart”—chaotic thoughts in their minds, muttered words under tense, heavy air, prayers to a God, and pleas spoken in fear.

Those “shadows” did not open their mouths, yet their voices swept over the platform on the shore like a storm.

Duncan’s heart stirred. He suddenly turned his head.

In the pale and dim sky far away, he saw a tall shape.

A guillotine—its sharp blade gleamed with cold light in the gloom.

With the little historical knowledge in his mind, and by linking it to the origin of Anomaly 099, Duncan realized where he was.

He looked under the guillotine. As his understanding settled, a blurry figure beneath the blade quickly became clear.

He saw the Queen. The Frostholm Queen who had been executed by rebels half a century ago. Her silver hair hung like a waterfall, and her pale violet eyes still shone bright in the dimness. She wore a dress that looked a bit too thin for the cold wind, yet she gritted her teeth and did not let her body tremble at all.

She really did have the exact same face as Alice.

Something strange rose in Duncan's heart. He looked at the lady whose face was exactly the same as Alice's. Even though he knew this was the "real one" recorded in history, he still could not help but first picture the lively Doll on the ship in his mind. The next second, a voice suddenly came from nowhere and cut off his thoughts—

"Your time is up, Frostholm 'queen'."

The voice was cold and distant, yet it echoed beside the guillotine as if it had pierced the Veil of history.

In the next moment, two phantom figures suddenly appeared beside the guillotine. They walked to the Frostholm Queen, as if to push down her arms and force her to kneel under the blade. But the Queen's posture did not move at all. Her figure stood firm, while those two tall phantoms were as weak and powerless as children.

Duncan heard the noisy sound around him grow even more violent than before. Countless black shadows started to sway. Here and there, some clear shouts mixed into the chaos. That same cold and distant voice rang out again, this time with a bit of anger: "Silence! Keep order on the execution ground!"

More phantom figures appeared around the guillotine. The Frostholm Queen was finally forced down beneath that cold instrument of death. She knelt in the freezing dust, yet still raised her head and calmly fixed her gaze

on the tall walls of the distant city-state. Above her neck, the heavy, sharp blade began to rise, ratcheting upward with the squeak of a winch…

Duncan frowned. Even though he knew this was only an illusion recorded by history, when he saw “Alice’s” face, he still stepped forward without thinking, reaching out his hand…

But just as he moved, the Frostholm Queen under the guillotine turned her head a little. She looked toward where Duncan was floating, looking straight at the place that should have been empty in her own time and space. She opened her mouth and spoke, clear yet soft:

“Whoever you are, please do not corrupt history.”

Duncan stopped in shock. Right after that, he was even more shocked to hear someone beside the guillotine cry out: “Who are you talking to?!”

The Frostholm Queen had already looked away. She seemed to suddenly understand something. A faint, relieved smile appeared on her once-cold face. She turned her head, as if speaking to the executioner next to her: “Do it, before the Sun sets.”

The guillotine dropped.

Boundless darkness surged in from all directions. The illusion of history tore into scattered pieces of light. Duncan felt his link with “this place” weaken fast. He knew this “echo” had reached its end. As the scene kept breaking and falling away, he still heard some broken, messy voices. They came and went, now near, now far. He could only make out a few fragments —

“…The Frostholm Queen is dead. We have cut off the channel for the Vanished to return to the Mortal Realm…”

“…Ray Nora tried to build a second Vanished… She colluded with the Shadows of Subspace. The evidence is ironclad. Death is too light a

sentence for her…”

“…The new Governor will soon restore order. All documents related to the Abyss Exploration Project will be destroyed… Those who report others actively still have a chance at mercy…”

“Pursue the rebel ship the Sea Mist and the mutinous navy with all our strength… their lives or deaths do not matter… Wait, what is that sound… Get out, this place is going to collapse!”

Cries of shock, shouts, the huge cracking roar of massive things breaking and falling, the howling rush of great waves…

Duncan tore free from the endless darkness, as if surfacing from a Deep Dive. At the very end of that darkness, what he heard was a chain of thunderous crashes, as if a whole cliff had crumbled off the coast into the sea.

He had witnessed a piece of history with his own eyes, and then heard that history fall into the void in the dark.

He had seen a phantom inside history, and that phantom had asked him not to corrupt history.

He slowly opened his eyes and saw the familiar cabin. He heard the familiar sound of waves. He also saw the familiar Doll sitting on the edge of the bed, happily playing by pulling her head off with a “pop” and then pushing it back on with another “pop”.

Duncan: “…?”

Chapter 101: The Open-Minded Alice

Duncan stared at Alice with a blank face, as if he were looking at an idiot.

The echo of history in his mind had not fully faded yet. The calm, all-seeing eyes of the Frostholm Queen from half a century ago still lingered in his thoughts. But that solemn afterimage, which should have filled him with heavy feelings, now smashed right into Alice, this idiot Doll. The clash did not only grind it to pieces, it even started to twist it into a joke under the repeated “pop-pop-pop” of her pulling off her own head.

He watched her like that for quite a while before finally losing his patience: “…What are you doing?”

“Ah! Captain!” Alice finally reacted, late as always. She hurried to hold her head with one hand and looked at Duncan. “Oh, I keep feeling like some hairs are stuck in the joint of my neck…”

Duncan’s face stayed blank: “If you yank it off a couple more times, you’ll have to give the new hair a name again.”

“I already did! If it falls out, they’ll be called the Williams family…”

Duncan used all his strength to keep his expression under control and stopped himself from throwing this Doll out of the cabin.

After a few seconds, he let out a long breath. His mood slowly calmed down.

To be fair, Alice's presence had indeed brought some much-needed cheer to the dead, gloomy atmosphere on the Vanished. But sometimes she brought too much cheer… Even Goathead often could not keep up with this Doll's pace. As for Duncan, most of the time he had no idea what kind of structure was inside this thing's skull.

It might even be solid.

Duncan's gaze slid over Alice, and he could not help recalling the "echo" he had just seen in that dark space. His expression grew serious, and the details in that echo made him frown.

He was sure that he had seen the Frostholm Queen, Ray Nora, the one who was said to have been executed by rebels half a century ago. She was the "original" mentioned in the background information of Anomaly 099, the one this Doll Alice was modeled after. He had seen the scene of her "execution", and the cause of that scene no doubt lay in the "Doll's spirit coffin" before him.

The spirit form fire had linked him to the spirit coffin.

But what was the nature of those images? Was the spirit coffin consciously showing him something? Were they passive "recordings"? Were they the memories of Anomaly 099? Were they real fragments of history, or distorted "visions" with some kind of correction mixed in?

In his mind, he saw again the calm look of that young Queen when she gazed at him, and he recalled her soft request—

"Whoever you are, please do not corrupt history."

Who was that line meant for? Was it really meant for him? Did those words truly cross time itself? Or was it only an illusion drawn by the spirit coffin, reacting to his "visit" in some way? And after the Queen said those words, a

frightened voice under the guillotine had asked her who she was talking to…

Those linked reactions had all felt so real. So real they sent a chill down his spine.

As for the end of that “echo”, the voices he heard from the dark made Duncan even more uneasy.

One of the charges against the Frostholm Queen in her rebel-led trial had been “trying to bring the Vanished into the Mortal Realm” and “building a second Vanished”. There was also that “Abyss Exploration Project”, which seemed to be one of the reasons she had been abandoned by everyone… Yet he had never heard Goathead mention any of this!

Goathead often bragged to him about the “great deeds” of the Vanished—how many ships it had swallowed on some route, what kind of huge uproars it had caused in certain city-states. Even if eight out of ten things he said were not reliable, if there really had been a City Lord who “colluded” with the Vanished, Goathead would have told the story long ago. That guy would happily make up three thousand words for no reason at all, let alone for something this big!

Unless… the whole thing was fake, a charge the rebels had fabricated for the Queen.

“Captain? Captain, are you okay?”

Alice’s voice suddenly came from beside him and cut off Duncan’s wild thoughts.

Duncan let out a slow breath and forced the messy thoughts in his head back down. He glanced at Alice, wanting to find a little trace of “Frostholm Queen Ray Nora” in her. But he quickly shook his head and said: “I’m fine. I just saw a bit of the ‘record’ stored inside the spirit coffin.”

“Record?” Alice’s eyes went wide with curiosity. “What kind of record?”

“The scene of the Frostholm Queen’s beheading fifty years ago,” Duncan said calmly. “I saw her—she really looks exactly like you.”

Alice at once reached up to touch her neck. Miss Doll did not know whether she should feel nervous or feel that this was nothing special. She hesitated for quite a while before finally managing to squeeze out a line: “Could I actually be that Frostholm Queen? After I was beheaded, I didn’t die, but instead got changed by some supernatural power and became what I am now?”

Duncan thought about it for a long moment, then answered honestly: “If you didn’t talk, didn’t move, and just lay quietly in that box, I really would think so.”

Alice tried to process that, but failed to get it.

She soon tossed that little confusion aside though, and instead looked very seriously at her spirit coffin: “Then after you… burned it with that ‘fire’, did it change in any way? Did you manage to control it?”

Only then did Duncan turn his full attention back to the wooden box and carefully feel the link that still remained between him and it.

The flame had faded, but the mark it left was still there.

In his unseen senses, he could clearly “see” the mark he had left inside the spirit coffin, and he could feel the thin threads of connection between him and it. It was a bit like the link between him and the mutated Sun emblem, but it was far more complex and far more subtle.

Putting aside the huge mystery of the information stored inside the spirit coffin, he had indeed managed to establish a connection with the thing. But unlike the simple structure of the Sun emblem, he had no idea how to control the spirit coffin.

He could not even sense any “option” for control in it.

He could only be sure of one thing: the spirit coffin was now very calm, very… “tame”.

After the flame passed over it, it seemed to be completely “domesticated”, as if it had become… a part of the Vanished.

“I’m not sure. We may need more tests to know whether it’s truly safe, and even more tests to figure out whether the ‘beheading’ effect comes from the spirit coffin or from you,” Duncan said with a shake of his head. “But from what I can feel right now, it is very ‘obedient’, just like most other items on the Vanished…”

As he spoke, he turned his head to look at the Doll beside him.

“The key now is you—do you feel any Anomaly?”

Alice pointed at herself in surprise: “Me? I don’t. Why are you asking?”

“You and your box are one whole. Together, the two of you make ‘Anomaly 099’. Now that I’ve used the flame to seize the spirit coffin’s authority, you as the Doll might be affected,” Duncan said, looking at Alice very seriously. He knew this Doll was slow to react, so he had gotten used to spelling things out for her. “Move around a bit. If anything feels wrong, tell me.”

Only then did Alice finally react. She quickly jumped up to check herself. She ran around the room twice, then hopped in place a few times. At last she returned to the box and crooked her finger at it.

The box did not move at all.

“It… it, it won’t listen anymore!” Alice cried out, finally noticing something big was wrong. “Before, all I had to do was give an order and it would float right up!”

Something stirred in Duncan’s heart. When Alice had crooked her finger at the box, he had indeed felt a tiny response from the spirit coffin. But…

The spirit coffin was waiting for his command.

His eyebrow twitched, and he suddenly felt a bit awkward: “Maybe… after coming into contact with the spirit form fire, the spirit coffin now sees me as a higher-level ‘master’.”

Alice stared at the Captain in shock. Then her expression turned pitiful and wronged in a way that could be seen with the naked eye.

“But it’s fine. I can remove my hold on it,” Duncan said at once, even more embarrassed the more aggrieved the Doll looked. He waved his hand quickly. “It will still obey your orders.”

Alice blinked, then turned and crooked her finger at the box again. This time, she finally saw the box respond to her command once more, just as it always had.

Miss Doll at once broke into a huge smile. After letting the box land back on the floor, she rushed over and hugged its lid tight: “Great! I thought you weren’t going to listen to me anymore!”

Duncan watched Miss Doll’s emotions flip so fast with a very odd look on his face. After holding it in for a while, he finally said: “Sometimes… I really envy your open-minded attitude toward life.”

When Alice heard this, she froze, then took a long time to think, and still did not get what he meant…

“Forget it. As long as you’re happy,” Duncan sighed. “Are you sure there’s nothing wrong with your body?”

“No,” Alice lowered her head to look herself over. “Nothing feels uncomfortable at all. Actually… I feel kind of better than before?”

“Better than before?”

“I can’t explain it. I just feel… my body is very light? And there’s a steady, safe feeling too?” Alice thought hard, searching for words to describe her feelings. “It’s a bit like the feeling I had when I used to lie inside the box, that kind of peace. But now I’m standing outside the box, and I still feel just as safe…”

The Doll kept talking and thinking at the same time. Before Duncan could help her analyze it, she had already waved it off in her own open-minded way: “Oh well, it doesn’t matter. It’s not a bad thing anyway!”

Chapter 102: Goathead’s Nemesis

Alice accepted the fact that her crate had been rebuilt as a part of the Vanished without any fuss, then quickly pushed everything about Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm out of her mind. Her easy-going attitude was something Duncan could never hope to match.

According to the doll herself, she was so calm because she saw all of this as something outside of her, something that did not really belong to her.

Alice sat back down on the lid of her wooden crate with a happy smile and said: “Anyway, I live on this ship now and I don’t plan to leave. It is no big deal if the crate becomes part of the Vanished. The Frostholm queen thing is even simpler – I don’t even know her. I don’t know if I am her, or what kind of person she used to be. It was all half a century ago anyway… let history stay history.”

“As long as you can take it easy.” Duncan simply looked quietly into Alice’s pale violet eyes. After a long time, he nodded slightly.

In the end, he still did not bring up the “details” in the echo, and did not mention what Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm had suddenly said to him before her execution.

After all, even if he did, this doll would not know anything… and it was good that she could stay this carefree.

Duncan let out a soft breath and said: “All right. For now we have a basic grasp and control of your spirit coffin, but we still do not know if the

Decapitation effect of Anomaly 099 is under control as well. We will have to run more tests when we get the chance. I will go now."

"Take care, Captain~"

Leaving Alice's room, Duncan went back up to the deck. Full of thoughts, he walked slowly toward the captain's cabin, sorting through the problems they had run into so far.

He had set out to find out whether Anomaly 099's Decapitation power was controllable, but in the end he still had no answer. Instead, he had accidentally touched on an old case from half a century ago… the Frostholm queen who had been executed by rebels, the charge that she had colluded with the Vanished, and a mysterious plan called "Abyssal Dive". These things circled in his mind and would not fade.

Besides these, there was one more thing that bothered him.

Duncan reached into his coat and took out something.

It was a small hair clip shaped like a silver-white feather wrapped by sea waves.

No matter how he looked at it, it was not something a rough male seafarer would own.

Whenever he looked at it, he felt a distant and hazy sense of nostalgia. This hair clip seemed to have had a special meaning for the real "Captain Duncan" of the past.

Duncan was full of questions, but he knew he could not ask Goathead about this directly.

He put the hair clip away and, heavy with thoughts, returned to the captain's cabin. Goathead was still there, diligently steering the ship. To Duncan's

surprise, the pigeon AI, who was supposed to wait on standby in the bedroom, was there with him.

The bird was standing proudly on one of Goathead's horns, arrogantly rubbing its beak against Goathead's forehead.

Duncan opened the door and saw this scene. He could not help asking with curiosity: "Since when did you two get so close?"

The pigeon flapped its wings and stayed silent, acting aloof. Goathead creaked as he turned his head, his obsidian eyes staring straight at Duncan, and said: "Great Captain… next time you take AI walking through the Spirit Realm, could you bring back some fries?"

Duncan froze: "…How did you also start with this 'get some fries' thing?"

Goathead's voice almost trembled: "Please, get some fries… just so your pigeon will shut up…"

Duncan stared, dumbfounded, at the bird-and-goat pair. After a moment he roughly guessed what had happened and burst out laughing: "You finally met your natural enemy, huh?"

"I changed the subject seventy-six times! Seventy-six! I used everything I ever learned, across a thousand years of history, from poetry and songs to cooking and frying, from sacrifices to the gods to breeding sows! But every answer I got was 'get some fries'!" Goathead sounded on the verge of breaking down. "How do you usually deal with this pigeon?"

"Simple. Just talk less to it. If you don't talk to it, it will quiet down on its own very soon," Duncan spread his hands. "I guess you can't do that."

Goathead thought for a moment, then sighed: "…Then you should still get some fries later."

Duncan did not answer. He just beckoned to AI, and the pigeon flapped over at once to land on his shoulder. Only then did he sit in his chair and, as if casually, turn to Goathead and say: “The ruler of the city-state of Frostholm half a century ago, Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm – do you know anything about her?”

“The Frostholm queen? The one the rebels executed half a century ago?” Goathead paused in surprise. “I did hear about that. I remember we even fought a battle near there decades ago… but apart from that we did not have much contact. Why do you bring this up all of a sudden?”

Duncan looked calmly into Goathead’s eyes. He knew this “First Mate” was not lying.

Goathead truly did not know much about that Frostholm queen. The Vanished had never had any contact with that city-state.

Not only that, back then the Vanished had even clashed with that city’s guard forces – just like it had clashed with ships from other city-states and other routes.

Since, in Goathead’s memory, the Vanished had never been an ally of Frostholm, it meant the charge the rebels had put on the Frostholm queen fifty years ago was completely made up.

Of course, it might still be too early to draw that conclusion. After all, it was an old case from half a century ago, and there might be many twists buried in history. He also only had Goathead’s side of the story. This First Mate might be speaking honestly, but what he knew might not be the whole truth – yet none of that really mattered.

Duncan had no intention of overturning the Frostholm queen’s case from fifty years ago. He only wanted to know what was connected to the Vanished and to Alice.

“Did you know? Alice looks exactly like the Frostholm queen from fifty years ago. The so-called Anomaly 099 is very likely something born when the executed Frostholm queen was cursed by the Boundless Sea,” he said, idly playing with the pigeon on his shoulder. “And the main ‘crime’ that queen was executed for by the rebels back then was ‘colluding with the Vanished’.”

Goathead froze.

Duncan rarely saw this fellow stunned.

“Colluding with the Vanished?! Are the foolish humans in those city-states so bad at even betraying their own sovereign that they have to make up such a laughable excuse?” After several seconds, Goathead finally burst into loud laughter. He clearly found it absurd. “Do not blame me for laughing so loudly. Those humans are too stupid and weak. They would probably even blame the Vanished’s curse if they tripped and fell at their own door! This ‘crime’ is far too ridiculous.”

He paused, then went on: “But you said Miss Alice looks a lot like that Frostholm queen? That really is… unbelievable. If Miss Alice really did come from a transformation of that Frostholm queen… then this whole thing is full of irony.”

“Yes. If there really is a link between them, it is full of irony.” Duncan leaned back, settling into a comfortable position. “The Frostholm queen never had any contact with the Vanished while she was alive, yet the rebels forced a crime of colluding with the Vanished onto her. And now, half a century later, Alice really has become a crew member of the Vanished. The charge those rebels once forced on her turned real across time.”

“No wonder you rushed off to see Miss Alice as soon as you came back. So you found key information about Anomaly 099,” Goathead at once began to flatter him. “You truly are the great Captain Duncan. Every one of your

trips brings back a harvest! That reminds me of something a mariner once said, or maybe it was a…”

Duncan immediately glared at Goathead, then casually lifted the pigeon from his shoulder and set it down in front of him: “You two can talk.”

Goathead: “…!?”

…

In the city-state of Pland, inside the central Cathedral, Vanna handed a freshly signed document to her attendant and said: “Send this document to the western Cathedral – this is the last search warrant.”

The young Guardian Warrior took the document: “Yes, Inquisitor.”

Vanna let out a small breath and worked her neck, which had gone stiff from paperwork. She felt that dealing with pens was even more tiring than swinging her greatsword against heretics.

On the edge of the desk, an oil lamp burned quietly, and thin smoke rose from a brass censer. These two things were necessary protections when handling paperwork at night – even in the holy Cathedral, proper warding was still needed.

“I hope there won’t be any more trouble tonight.”

The young Inquisitor muttered this while stretching.

Almost as if to answer her words, just as Vanna finished speaking, a slightly hurried and sharp bell suddenly rang from the main building of the Cathedral.

The Guardian Warrior, who had just picked up the document and had not yet left, stopped at once when he heard it. He looked out the window in confusion, then at his superior whose stretch was only halfway done: “The night signal bell is ringing… what’s happened?”

“It’s the bell that gathers the Listening Rite.” Vanna quickly picked out the message in the sound, and her face grew serious at once. “Seven short rings in a row, from the Nameless King’s tomb… have they found a new Anomaly or new manifestations?”

Chapter 103: The Nameless King’s Tomb

The night signal bell rang three times, and before the third ring ended, Vanna had already reached the great hall.

Old Bishop Valentine was already waiting there. The respected elder wore a black priest’s robe and stood in silence before the holy statue of the storm Goddess Gamona with his eyes closed in prayer. When he heard someone step into the hall, he knew without turning that it was Vanna.

“Inquisitor Vanna,” Valentine said in a deep voice, “the Grand Cathedral of Storms has sent an order to gather Listeners.”

“Directly from the Grand Cathedral of Storms?!” Vanna was startled. She quickly stepped to the front of the statue, letting her whole body fall into the glow of the lamps. “So it isn’t just that they found a new Anomaly or new manifestations?”

“If it were only a new Anomaly or new manifestations, the signal bell would not ring three times in a row.” Valentine shook his head. “The news came straight from the Gravekeeper at the ‘tomb’. They say the body of the Nameless King is stirring. We still do not know what message He is trying to send, but it seems… the existing list is changing.”

As he spoke, the old Bishop turned his head and quietly met Vanna’s eyes.

“This time we need to send a Listener into the tomb itself to hear the information straight from the body of the Nameless King. Right now the

Deep Sea Church is on duty at the tomb, and the Listener will be chosen from the followers of the storm Goddess. The specific person has not been decided yet. You and I are both on the list of candidates."

Vanna steadied herself and asked calmly: "When do we leave?"

"Now." Valentine nodded and motioned for Vanna to follow. He walked toward the back of the Goddess's statue, where a door covered in sacred symbols already stood open, showing a deep, long passage beyond. "The psychic channel is ready."

Vanna bowed to Gamona's statue, then turned and followed the old Bishop.

They passed through the door and then along the long passage. In the flickering lamplight, the two devout believers reached the deepest part of the ancient Cathedral – a special secret room at the end of the corridor.

It was a small room. Unlike the Cathedral's main concrete and brick structure, this little chamber was built entirely of stone. Gray, uneven stones were packed tightly together to form the walls and ceiling. In the center of the room, the floor dipped into a fire pit. Flames crackled there, burning fiercely in the stone hollow – yet there was no fuel at the base of the fire, as if the flames had condensed from the air itself.

Aside from the flames in the center, the chamber held no furniture or decorations. Only a faint sound of running water came from nowhere, echoing from all directions. Every wall looked wet, and even the floor seemed to have tiny streams flowing over it at any time. It gave the feeling that this stone room was not a part of the Cathedral at all, but… a flooded cave on the seabed.

This was not Vanna's first time in this chamber. As an Inquisitor, whose rank in the city-state was equal to that of a Bishop, she also had the right to

use this psychic channel. This unremarkable room was the “port” that built the Channel.

Every city-state’s central Cathedral had similar facilities, and every Church had its own version of the same art. The priests of the storm Goddess used such “flooded caves”. The priests of the Death God built their connecting paths in “pale chambers”. These gloomy places actually had a wondrous purpose: they could peel a user’s spirit from the body and send it into a vast psychic space shared by all, no matter how far apart the city-states were or how wild the storms on the Boundless Sea became.

These sacred miracles were made possible by the divine blessing of the gods. They let distant branches of the Church on the Boundless Sea communicate in time. In older ages, when ocean-going ships were not as reliable as they are now, this was even the only way many city-states could keep in touch and confirm each other’s survival.

The chamber door slowly closed. The big dark metal door gave a dull thud, and the complex runes carved across its surface began to move quickly, tangling and locking together like living things, sealing the room completely.

Vanna and Valentine stood together by the fire pit at the center of the chamber. They lowered their heads, gazing at the leaping holy flames, and quietly recited the holy name of the storm Goddess Gamona.

The faint sound of water kept coming from all around them, and as they recited the name it grew louder. In the end the sound turned into waves, even roaring. A damp breath filled the whole room. In the growing humidity, Vanna saw the trickling streams on the floor suddenly turn into rolling waves that began to rise very fast.

She kept her eyes on the flames in the center of the room. The fire burned as steadily as ever, blazing within the rising waves.

Vanna closed her eyes and calmly let the phantom seawater drown her completely.

The cold touch faded quickly. When she opened her eyes again, she no longer stood in a flooded stone chamber. Instead she was in a vast, hazy space. It seemed to be a plaza, almost without end, old and grand. Many huge pillars stood at the edge of her sight. The tops of those pillars were all broken, as if shattered and scattered into the distant sky. A dim flow of light hung over the plaza, and something seemed to hide deep within that light, but it was not something mortal eyes could pierce.

Vanna steadied herself. She saw that many figures were already standing on the plaza – black silhouettes that only had outlines. She could not see their faces, but from the familiar auras each one gave off she knew they were all devout Saints of the storm Goddess. They came from many city-states, from the moving Cathedrals, and even from the Grand Cathedral of Storms.

Only Saints could be candidates to become Listeners – for some “voices”, only powerful Saints could complete the Listening rite and stay conscious.

“Looks like we are among the last ones.” A shadow drifted closer. Because they knew each other well, Vanna recognized him as Bishop Valentine even before he spoke. The old man’s tone sounded a bit embarrassed. “I was also the last to arrive at the last meeting…”

“Do the Saints from other city-states live in their secret rooms or something…” Vanna muttered. “Every time a summons goes out, half of them gather in less than ten minutes…”

“Ever since Saint Folsom wrote ‘first’ on the attendance book in the plaza twenty years ago, they have been competing to arrive early,” Valentine shook his head and said. “Honestly, I do not understand it. The Goddess will not give them extra favor for that.”

Vanna did not comment. Just then, a sudden rumbling sounded from the far end of the crowd, cutting off her thoughts and all the talk between the Saints' shadows.

Vanna and Valentine both looked up at the same time and saw the ground at the center of the plaza rising. The cracked old stone tiles rippled like water. In the overlapping waves, something huge was rising quickly. First came a pale spire, then slanted stone walls and old pillars.

In almost a moment, the thing came fully into Vanna's view – a huge building made of pale giant stones.

It was a gloomy "palace", an ancient building raised in a long-lost age. A pyramid formed its main body, with several obelisks and towers around it. No city-state in the world used such a style, and its heavy, suffocating air felt nothing like a place meant for the living.

Rather than a palace, it was more like a giant tomb.

In fact, that was exactly what it was – a tomb belonging to some ancient, mighty being.

Like everyone else, Vanna's gaze was drawn to the base of the great pyramid. Under countless watching eyes, the tomb's gate finally opened.

The heavy pale stone doors slid aside, and a very tall figure slowly walked out of the tomb.

It was the Gravekeeper of the Nameless King's tomb.

In Vanna's eyes, it was hard to say whether "he" was still a living human.

His body was wrapped in layer after layer of shroud. One half of his body and shroud were burned almost pitch black, while the other half was bound in heavy rune chains. Some of those grim chains even stretched straight out of his flesh, their tips wrapped around pulsing blood vessels and nerves.

This ancient Gravekeeper looked like a terrible creature made of mortal flesh, iron fetters, and a deathly curse. He stepped out of the Nameless King’s tomb and walked with heavy steps toward the shadows gathered on the plaza.

Even though this was not her first time seeing the Gravekeeper, Vanna still drew a breath without thinking, feeling her muscles tense.

Then she saw the Gravekeeper walk straight toward her.

The choice had been made.

The Gravekeeper passed every person on the plaza without hesitation until he stopped in front of Vanna. Only one eye was exposed on his head, the rest wrapped in shroud and chains. That single eye looked calmly at Vanna – though she was already quite tall, the Gravekeeper still stood a whole head above her.

“You may enter the tomb.” The Gravekeeper spoke, his voice hoarse, as if from a corpse. Then he raised his right hand, which looked as if it had been burned by fire. In it he held a quill and a roll of parchment.

“Write down what you hear.” The Gravekeeper gave his brief order.

Chapter 104: The Note

Looking at the quill and parchment sheet the Gravekeeper handed to her, Vanna took a quiet breath and forced her emotions to calm at once.

“How long can I stay inside?” She raised her head and fixed her gaze on the nameless Gravekeeper.

The Gravekeeper lowered his head a little. This being, who carried both the aspect of life and of death, seemed to weigh the strength of the soul before him, then gave a cold answer: “An instant, or eternity.”

This answer meant the message about to come from the burial chamber would be brief and singular, but it might point toward a very, very dangerous “source”, and the Listener might die because of it.

Vanna nodded lightly and withdrew her gaze from the Gravekeeper.

She stepped toward the great tomb not far away. The Gravekeeper followed behind her, dragging his decayed, dark chains across the ground with a sharp, grating noise. The shadowy figures gathered on the plaza only watched in silence, seeing off a chosen Saint as she went toward the mausoleum.

At the mausoleum’s gate, Vanna stopped. She looked up at the towering pale stone door. The ancient, desolate air it gave off stirred her heart a little.

This was not the first time she had seen this tomb in the psychic conclave, but it was the first time she had been chosen to enter it as a Listener.

Vision 004, the “Nameless King Mausoleum” — this ancient burial place, lodged in some strange rift of time and space, was not a Vision controlled by the Deep Sea Church. It was an ancient relic guarded in turns and shared by all the orthodox Churches. From the outside, it was a mausoleum in the heavy style of the ancient kingdom of Critt, and all the evidence that existed showed that this tomb really was a legacy left by that old kingdom. Yet no one knew who had built it, and no one knew why this ancient mausoleum had become a “Vision”.

People only knew that the Master inside this tomb would, from time to time, send messages to the outside world. The corruption carried in those messages was, in most cases, enough to kill a mortal. Yet on the other hand, the messages were reliable and precise enough to reveal the “true information” about certain powerful Anomalies and Visions directly.

Whenever the Master of the tomb sent a message out, a “Gravekeeper” would come forth from the burial chamber and choose a Listener to enter the mausoleum. The Gravekeeper himself was part of Vision 004. He had no name or surname, was loyal to his post, and kept its secrets. He would first choose from the souls gathered near the plaza, and if there were none, he would randomly take a chosen one from anywhere in the world.

In the age before people had summed up the patterns of Vision 004, such “random choosing” had taken hundreds, even thousands of lives — until, thousands of years ago, the birth of a natural-born Saint broke this terrible cycle for the first time.

That Saint came back alive from the Nameless King Mausoleum and made public the first gift from the “Nameless King”: the first list of Anomalies and Visions.

Everyone knew that the classification system and list of Anomalies and Visions were a gift left to later generations by the ancient kingdom of Critt.

Very few, however, knew how that gift had truly entered the world. The ancient kingdom had left behind Vision 004, and only after thousands of failed selections did Vision 004 finally manage to reveal the first version of the register.

Only after that did the major Churches slowly learn how to use the psychic conclave to approach the tomb on purpose and send Saints as “Listeners”, so that this ancient Vision could be used by people in a relatively safe way.

“Enter the mausoleum and prepare the Listening Rite.” The Gravekeeper’s low, hoarse voice came from behind her, and Vanna stepped forward.

The sound of the stone door closing slowly came from behind her, and the Gravekeeper’s presence faded from the air at the same time. That ancient Warden once more became part of the mausoleum. Now he watched every move of the soul that had entered the tomb through invisible senses.

Pale flames flared up along both sides of the corridor leading to the chamber. Vanna followed the path lit by the fire deeper into the tomb. Her gaze swept over the walls on both sides. On the walls built of massive stones, she could just make out “markings” that looked as if they had been scraped out by fingernails.

“Walk straight ahead. Do not look back.”

“Do not ask the Gravekeeper about the Master of the chamber, or about his name.”

“Do not run, do not shout, and do not pray to any deity.”

“Keep humility and awe, but do not kneel.”

“After you enter the chamber, do not speak.”

These were the records left over countless years by countless “Listeners”. In ancient times, most Listeners died in this passageway. Among them,

perhaps one in a hundred, or even one in a thousand, had enough strength to leave these warnings for those who came after, in the last moments before their death.

These precious “reminders” had long since been written into the manuals each Church used to train Saints. Vanna knew them by heart and did not dare forget a single word.

But at that moment Vanna suddenly felt a bit curious. She had heard that there were reminders left by her predecessors in this passage, but she had not expected to find only these reminders. What about the hysterical ones, the ones who went mad, the ones who lost hope at the end and begged in despair, or raged and destroyed things? Had they not left any traces in this passage?

Human nature was complex. Before the Churches managed to gain control over Vision 004, the Gravekeeper had brought hundreds and thousands of people in here. Among them there must have been those whose minds broke, those who blamed heaven and earth, and surely there had been people who carved mad ravings on the walls of the passage, even curses spat at the curse itself… Yet all the way here, Vanna had seen only the encouragements and admonitions left by her predecessors, as if…

As if only steadfast and noble souls were allowed to leave marks here.

Vanna felt a bit confused, but in the end she did not call out to the Gravekeeper to ask her questions.

In theory, she could speak to the Gravekeeper while still in the passage. That did not go against the tomb’s “rules”, and there were indeed records of the Gravekeeper answering Visitors and even taking the initiative to explain things. But this was Vanna’s first time entering as a Listener. She was very cautious and dared not do anything extra.

With her nerves stretched tight like this, the young Inquisitor finally reached the end of the passage. In the wavering light ahead, she could already see the “Nameless King Chamber” at the very deepest point.

She stepped through the stone door at the corridor’s end.

A wide, ancient burial chamber appeared before her eyes.

Inside the great pyramid-shaped room, the four slanting pale stone walls were covered with blurred markings. Two rows of dark metal braziers stood on either side of the entrance. Pale flames burned in them, sending up hazy smoke. In the center of the chamber there was no coffin or anything like it — only a stone chair. On that chair sat the Master of the mausoleum.

It was a headless body that seemed to belong to a tall man. His limbs were held fast by chains. His arms and chest were covered in thick black hair like an animal’s. His feet were twisted and deformed, like warped animal limbs, and at the same time looked as if they had been burned by fierce flames, blackened and rotten.

This body simply sat still on the throne, as if it had no reaction at all to Vanna’s visit.

But Vanna remembered clearly what she had been taught. The moment she saw the “Nameless King”, she took out the parchment sheet and the quill. She gathered her mind to face the coming mental corruption and got ready to write down what she heard…

Vanna opened her eyes.

She saw that she was lying flat on the ground of the gathering plaza. The distant, towering broken pillars linked the chaotic sky with the shattered earth. Farther away, clusters of shadowy figures were gathered.

Several shadows were walking toward her. One of them seemed to be Valentine, the Bishop.

“You are awake. Leave.”

The Gravekeeper’s hoarse, low voice suddenly came from beside her. Startled, Vanna raised her head with difficulty and saw that she was lying right at the entrance of Vision 004. Out of the corner of her eye she saw the tall Gravekeeper turning to step through the stone door of the mausoleum. Then there was a loud rumble. The huge tomb sank quickly down beside her and vanished into the plaza’s floor.

Before Vanna could react to what had happened, several shadows had already reached her side. One of them spoke in Valentine the Bishop’s voice: “Vanna, are you all right? I saw you walk out of the mausoleum and collapse right at the door…”

“I…” Vanna slowly pushed herself up. She felt as if all her strength had been drained away, but now it was slowly returning, and that let her head clear bit by bit. “How long was I inside?”

“An instant,” another Saint’s shadow beside her said in a deep voice. “You went through the door, it closed once, and then you walked back out again.”

Vanna froze for a moment. Then she heard Valentine the Bishop speak again: “What about the parchment sheet? Look at what you wrote.”

“Oh, right, the parchment sheet!” Vanna finally came fully to herself and at once felt that she was indeed holding something. She quickly lifted her hand — and in the next second, her gaze froze.

The parchment sheet that had been whole in her hand was now, for some reason, only a tiny torn scrap. On the little piece a few centimeters long, there were only a few scrawled numbers and letters:

“Anomaly 099 – Doll.”

Chapter 105: After the Gathering

Anomaly 099 – Doll.

That was all that remained on the parchment sheet. It was the only piece of information Vanna had brought back from the Nameless King Mausoleum.

The moment she saw those scrawled letters, Vanna's face went blank. She could feel that Valentine the Bishop and the other figures beside her were just as stunned. After a brief silence, one of the Saints' shadows suddenly spoke in a low voice: "An existing Anomaly has been changed out of nowhere… and it happened outside the civilized world's sight."

"It has fallen into the hands of the Vanished," another Saint said with a nod. "Maybe that ghost captain did something…"

"But what kind of change could give this result?" The Saint who had spoken first sounded deeply worried. "Doll: spirit coffin and Doll differ by more than just a few letters… and this change stirred the Nameless King Mausoleum directly, even making the Gravekeeper suddenly call a Listener into the chamber to deliver this piece of information…"

The Saints discussed in low, grave voices, and in the end their gazes all fell back on Vanna. By then Vanna had mostly recovered. With Valentine the Bishop's help she stood up, looked at the scrap of paper in her hand, and said: "…I don't remember anything that happened in the chamber. I only remember walking in the passage."

"Forgetting what happened inside the chamber is normal. Your mind is protecting itself. That is why we need the parchment sheet and the quill the

Gravekeeper provides, to record the useful information," Valentine the Bishop said slowly. "But your parchment sheet has only these few words left. That is… not quite right."

Vanna stared blankly at her own hands. After a long time, she muttered hesitantly: "Did I tear the parchment sheet myself…"

"In theory, it could only be you," Valentine the Bishop said as he looked at her. "There is no one else inside the mausoleum. The Gravekeeper never interferes with the exchange between a Listener and the Master of the chamber, and the Master does nothing beyond delivering the message."

Confusion swelled in Vanna's heart. Before she could speak again, a deep, solemn female voice suddenly came from the edge of the plaza and cut off the Saints' discussion: "The time for this gathering to end is almost here."

The Saints all straightened at once and turned toward the source of the voice. Vanna quickly composed herself and looked to the figure at the far end of the plaza — a woman in what seemed to be splendid robes stood there in silence, casting her gaze over each of the gathered Saints.

There were no attendants at the woman's side. She stood there alone, yet her presence and authority were more than enough. Like the other "souls", she appeared as a black silhouette, but her shadow was clearer and more solid than anyone else's, so solid that one could faintly see the outline of her features and see that she was a dignified, noble-looking woman.

Filled with awe, Vanna bowed her head slightly to that figure.

That was the leader of the Deep Sea Church, the vicar of the Storm Goddess Gamona in the mortal world, the Pope who sat in the Storm Cathedral. This supernatural, blessed by the deity, was so powerful that even her soul had changed in nature. Even in this field of the psychic conclave, she could faintly show the full outline of a "human" form.

Even the Saints, whose power far surpassed that of ordinary supernaturals, could only barely keep a human outline in this gathering place.

Vanna felt the Pope's gaze fall on her.

"You have already done very well, Saint Vanna," the Pope said with a small nod. Her voice was solemn yet gentle, soothing Vanna's faint disappointment. "How much information a Listener can bring out of the chamber has never been something we can control, and many times the information does not only exist on the parchment sheet."

"You mean…" Vanna looked up in curiosity and asked, mustering her courage.

"The less content remains on the parchment sheet, the more dangerous the information the Master of the chamber has given. It was your Spiritual Insight warning you, driving you to destroy the words you wrote in the chamber, so that that dangerous Truth would not be revealed to the world. This single piece of information is enough. It is enough for the Storm Cathedral to use as a reference to chart the coming course and to offer specific prayers to our Lord for guidance."

Vanna listened carefully to the Pope's words, and her mood slowly settled.

She knew this was not a casual comfort. Her Eminence the Pope would not do anything so meaningless. Since Her Eminence had said this, it meant that this matter had, to some extent, already gained the Goddess's approval.

She had already brought out information of enough value from the Nameless King Mausoleum.

"Disperse for now," the graceful Lady said softly. "This gathering is at an end. The Storm Cathedral will carefully evaluate the signal Vision 004 has given this time. If necessary, I shall issue further decrees or summon the Saints again."

Vanna quickly steadied herself. She bowed toward the Pope in salute, and then her figure slowly faded in this vast, chaotic space. The shadows of the other Saints disappeared from the plaza one after another. In the blink of an eye, the place was silent again.

In the great gathering ground, only the old cracked stone slabs, the pillars that held up the chaotic sky, and the spirit projection of the Storm Pope Helena remained.

This Pope, favored by Gamona, did not leave. After dissolving the gathering, she still stood quietly on the plaza, unmoving, staring at the empty space in the center.

After who knew how long, Helena suddenly turned her head and looked to a spot not far from her side. The air there rippled like water, and in an instant a tall, thin figure appeared in her sight.

The tall, thin figure seemed to be wearing robes. Like Helena, his features could also be faintly made out — he was an elderly man with a stern expression.

Then another figure appeared beside the tall, stern old man. This one was a short, plump elder, his face also faintly visible and wearing a kind smile.

“Banster.” Helena first nodded to the tall, stern old man, then looked toward the short, kindly smiling elder. “Rune — what is this? Are you both very free? Does the Church of Death and the Truth Academy not need to patrol the border?”

“The border has been stable lately. Reliable monitors are in place,” said the tall, thin elder called Banster, in brief words.

“We have temporarily handed the patrol duties at the border to reliable people,” the short, plump elder named Rune said with a nod. “This time we

mostly came to see how things are on your side… It looks like the civilized world is not very peaceful."

"The last time the mausoleum had a similar situation was also during the period when the Deep Sea Church was on watch," Banster said, his face blank. "About a hundred years ago, I think?"

"You know perfectly well," Helena said calmly. "Of course it was a hundred years ago. That time I went into the mausoleum myself as the Listener. Back then I was not yet the head of the Storm Cathedral. I remember it clearly."

"Yes, last time it was you who went in. I remember it very well too," Rune said, stroking his beard with some emotion. "You were also thrown out by the mausoleum right after you went in and stayed dizzy for a long time before you woke up. And just like that little young lady today, the parchment sheet you took into the chamber ended up as only a small slip, with only a few scrawled letters on it. Helena, do you still remember what message you brought out of the chamber a century ago?"

The head of the Storm Cathedral was silent for a moment before she said softly: "I remember it clearly — 'Vision 005 – the Vanished'."

Rune nodded lightly. "Yes. You were the first to bring back the news that the Vanished had become a Vision… And the few letters you brought back then were confirmed in less than a month. The phantom of the Vanished roared past the edge of the Church of Death's great cemetery, and this unlucky fellow Banster here watched his brand-new escort ship get swallowed whole before he could even cut the ribbon. Only the ribbon rope was left…"

Banster, Pope of the Church of Death, gave Rune a blank look.

Helena seemed not to hear Rune's last few words. She only stayed silent in thought, and after a long time she slowly said: "Whether it is 'Doll' or 'Doll: spirit coffin', it is only an Anomaly ranked near the nineties. It cannot be compared to a Vision ranked fifth."

"There is no comparison, but you also know that the key is not the information left on the slip," Rune said, his expression finally turning serious. "It is the part that could not be left. It is the Truth that can push even a Saint's mind to the edge of collapse, so that, driven by instinct, they must destroy it and bury it in the chamber. The fact that Anomaly 099's name has changed from 'Doll: spirit coffin' to 'Doll' alone is nothing. It is the information related to it, but now hidden, that is deadly…"

"At present, the only direction for our guesses is that this is connected to that ghost ship," Helena said. "But a few days ago, when I sought enlightenment from the Lord…"

She stopped suddenly there, then shook her head, as if she did not intend to continue that topic.

"Why did Frem not come?" she asked, looking at the two figures before her. "Does he not always enjoy a spectacle too?"

"Frem and his Flamebearer Church are busy with something very important," the short, plump Rune said with a smile. "The leaders of the four orthodox Churches cannot all crowd over here just to watch the fun…"

"Something very important?" Helena frowned. "What is he doing?"

"Patrolling the border," Banster said, brief as ever.

Helena: "…"

Chapter 106: Duncan’s Gift

The phantom seawater faded as fast as a dream at dawn. Vanna’s mind returned to her body. After one deep breath, she snapped her eyes open and saw that she still stood in the rocky chamber that felt like an underwater cave. A blaze burned fiercely before her.

She looked to the side and saw Bishop Valentine also opening his eyes.

The memories of the psychic conclave were still clear in her mind. Vanna looked down at her palm without thinking. Of course, her hand was empty. The parchment sheet that had only existed in the hall of the gathering had not come back with her to the Mortal Realm.

“We only just sent out a notice, telling the Deep-Sea Captains about the Doll spirit coffin’s runaway state,” Bishop Valentine sighed. “Now it seems we have to issue a new notice again.”

Vanna flexed her wrist and looked at the bishop, deep in thought: “The problem is… how do we write that notice? Other than the fact that Anomaly 099’s name changed, we don’t know anything.”

The old bishop did not speak for a moment. Clearly, he also felt this was a tricky problem.

Vanna had brought back news from Vision 004. Yet that message was only the new name of Anomaly 099. She had probably heard more detailed information from the Master of that tomb, maybe even heard about the new traits Anomaly 099 gained after it was renamed “Doll”. But that part of the

content had clearly been left forever in the main burial chamber along with the shredded parchment sheet.

“At this stage, we can only first announce that Anomaly 099 has been renamed from ‘Doll spirit coffin’ to ‘Doll’, and at the same time correct every description of Anomaly 099’s traits to ‘possible mutation’,” Valentine finally said after a long silence. “It is an Anomaly within the first hundred numbers. A change in its name will definitely come with a chain of effects. Its power, trigger conditions, sealing conditions, and even its outward signs are all very likely to have changed as well. If we keep dealing with it according to the old data, something big will probably happen…”

Vanna nodded in silence.

Anomaly 099’s number had not changed. Its absolute danger and strangeness probably had not changed much either. But for humans, it had already turned from a known Anomaly into an unknown Anomaly. The experience piled up with countless lives had turned to nothing, and “the unknown” had become its greatest danger now.

After the last notice went out, the captains on the Boundless Sea might still have tried, when they met Anomaly 099, to re-contain and seal the Doll spirit coffin using the experience in the old files. But starting today… when anyone ran into “Doll”, their only choice would be to get away at once and hope the Guardians of the four Orthodox Churches could seal it again.

The chamber fell silent for a while. Vanna and Valentine both thought about their own concerns. The mood lasted for who knew how long before Vanna suddenly broke the silence: “…All the numbers for the Anomalies and Visions in the world come from Vision 004, right?”

“Of course,” Valentine nodded. “Why did you suddenly ask that?”

“I’m thinking… who exactly are the nameless corpses in that tomb, and that Gravekeeper who is always so silent,” Vanna said thoughtfully. “They obviously are not humans, and they’re not beings of the Mortal Realm either. They’re not a God, and they’re not the Shadows of the Elder Gods in Subspace… Why would a Vision that can interact with the outside world choose this way to ‘help’ people? And how does the Master of the tomb decide the list of Anomalies and Visions?”

Valentine looked into Vanna’s eyes and waited until she finished asking all her questions. Then he sighed: “This was your first time entering the tomb as a Listener. Most people come out of there with just as many questions as you. But sadly, after so many years, even though we know more and more about Anomalies and Visions, we still cannot touch the true nature of Vision 004. That tomb… never explains anything about itself.”

“I remember you also entered that tomb once,” Vanna turned her head and looked at the old bishop with curiosity. “What information did you bring out back then? Was it also about Anomalies or Visions?”

“Not exactly,” Valentine shook his head. “Most of the time, the tomb does announce things related to Anomalies or Visions. But the Master of the tomb also sometimes passes out other things. Sometimes they’re even very… strange or useless pieces of information. When the Gravekeeper summons you, no one can be sure what the Master of the tomb wants to send out. The only thing we can be sure of is that any message from the tomb is true…”

Vanna still looked at the old bishop, curious: “Then what message did you bring out that time?”

The old bishop looked a bit torn. “It wasn’t very useful. Just… one sentence.”

His intent to dodge was obvious, but Vanna was stubborn and did not notice at all. “So what was it exactly?”

Valentine gave the hard-headed Inquisitor a helpless look and spread his hands: “On July twenty-fourth, the weather in Pland will be clear, with a southeast wind of force four to six.”

Vanna: “…?”

“Don’t look at me like that. Sometimes that’s the kind of information it gives,” Valentine said, rubbing his forehead. “Anomalies and Visions are unfathomable, and this ‘unfathomable’ nature shows up in all kinds of ways. I just happened to get a very special case… If you want to laugh, could you at least turn around? I’m already this old…”

“Sorry,” Vanna tried hard to keep a straight face, then turned away as she spoke. “But to be honest, I’m a little jealous. Hearing a weather report is better than going through something this bizarre and eerie today. Nothing happening is the best outcome, isn’t it?”

“…Fine, I’ll believe you,” he muttered.

…

At the edge of the Upper City, in an older stand-alone house, Heidi stared without expression at her slightly uneasy father: “So… the other day you went to visit a student’s home. You spent several hours chatting idly with the student’s parents, and only took twenty minutes to talk about the student’s situation. Then, when you left, you spent more than three thousand Sola to buy an old dagger and a fake crystal pendant made of glass?!”

Morris sat behind the table. A purple crystal pendant lay on the table, its tag already removed. The shelves behind him were full of all kinds of collectibles. He wiped sweat that wasn’t actually on his forehead, looking a bit embarrassed. “The pendant didn’t cost money. It was a free gift…”

“That makes it even worse that you treated it as my birthday present, doesn’t it?!” Heidi groaned and covered her forehead. “You could at least have pretended you picked it with care…”

Morris thought about it seriously, then spread his hands in helplessness. “There really wasn’t a second real item in that shop. There was nothing else I could choose.”

Heidi: “…”

After they glared at each other in anger for a few more seconds, she finally couldn’t hold it in and gave up first. “Forget it, forget it. It’s not the first time anyway… Why are you always the one getting taken advantage of?”

“I didn’t lose this time! The one who lost out was that Mr. Duncan,” Morris said at once. “I bought that dagger for twenty percent less than market price.”

Heidi had been shaking her head and sighing, but froze when she heard her father mention that name. “The shopkeeper of that antique shop is named Duncan?”

“Ah, yes, his name is Duncan Strenn,” Morris said casually. “There has always been a rumor that he’s a drunkard and a gambling addict, but after actually meeting him I found out that rumor really does people harm. He’s clearly a witty, humorous man with very broad knowledge… Hm? Why do you have that look? Is there something wrong with that name?”

Heidi opened her mouth and hesitated before she answered: “Sigh, I’m working on a very tricky ‘case’ right now, and it happens to be linked to that name. Hearing it just makes my nerves twitch a little.”

“It’s a very common name. There are plenty of people with it,” Morris nodded, then got a bit curious. “What kind of case is it?”

“It’s not your field, so don’t ask. It definitely can’t be the same person anyway,” Heidi waved a hand. “How could a terrifying ghost-ship captain and a shopkeeper who runs an antique shop in the Lower City be the same man?”

“Of course not,” Morris let out a breath of relief when he heard that. He knew his daughter often worked as a consultant for City Hall and even the Church on dangerous cases, sometimes even involving the supernatural, so he was naturally a bit nervous about that. Now he relaxed and let his gaze fall back on the crystal pendant on the table. “So, do you still want this pendant or not?”

“Yes! Of course I want it!” Heidi grabbed the pendant off the table. “It’s rare enough that you remember to bring me a gift at all, even if it’s a freebie.”

Morris thought for a moment and then offered a very serious suggestion: “Actually, you could pretend that I spent more than three thousand Sola on the pendant, and the dagger was the free gift.”

Heidi hung the pendant around her neck and gave Morris a look. “If you really spent over three thousand Sola to fall for that scam, I would tie you up and drag you into my treatment room myself!”

Chapter 107: Highly Contagious

Gentle waves rose and fell. The Vanished sailed smoothly across the Boundless Sea. After many days under sail, this ancient ghost ship still had not found any island or beacon that could serve as a mark of the route.

The long drifting journey seemed to have no end, but its captain still had many things to keep him busy.

Duncan returned once more to the captain’s cabin. The golden Sun mask still lay quietly on the table, but before he dealt with that, he had other matters to think about.

He could make arrangements for Alice later. The follow-up tests and research on Anomaly 099 were not urgent either. The Frostholm rebellion from half a century ago was even less something he needed to investigate right now. But aside from these matters, there was one more thing that was closely tied to himself.

Duncan raised his head and looked at the mirror hanging on the wall.

The green flames that had once floated on the mirror’s surface had long since faded. The distant scenes that had once appeared in the mirror had also vanished without a trace. Yet Duncan could still faintly feel that the weak and blurry “connection” had not disappeared with the reflection. It was still there, pointing far away toward the great Cathedral at the center of the city-state of Pland.

This connection felt a bit like the link between himself and the “antique shopkeeper” and the “White Oak”, but even weaker and more ethereal. If he

had to describe it… it was like some kind of offshoot, a secondary channel branching out from a clear and solid link.

Duncan closed his eyes a little. On the table beside him, the brass spirit compass on AI's chest quietly opened a narrow gap. A dim green flame burned quietly inside it.

Duncan returned again to that dark space filled with countless starlights and streams of light.

But this time, he did not carry out a full "Spirit Realm walk". He only stayed at the Critical Threshold of entering the Spirit Realm and watched carefully as the faint lights and the scattered points of light moved through the darkness.

He first saw the brightest "star". That star pointed toward the antique shop and stood for his other body. That body was cleaning the storeroom and checking the stock at the same time.

He then saw a hazy, shapeless cloud of light, much larger than any normal star. That represented the "White Oak", a steamship that had once crashed head-on into the Vanished and been completely burned through by the fire of his spirit form.

Finally, in a patch of hazy starlight that looked almost no different from the rest, he picked out the "star" that had a faint link to himself.

Duncan leaned closer in curiosity, wanting to study this cluster of starlight.

But as soon as he drew near, he felt a subtle repelling force spread out from that starlight.

The repelling force was not very strong. It felt like a pure, firm will that was protecting itself. Duncan felt that if he forced the fire of his spirit form to spread toward it, he could probably burn away this instinctive protection. But he still stopped at once and kept a distance from that starlight.

The master behind this starlight should be that Inquisitor named “Vanna”, a Storm Saint and a powerful supernatural. If he acted too recklessly, he might startle the starlight’s master first, and in the worst case, might even alarm the “God” who stood behind that Saint.

While he still knew very little about the Gods of this world, Duncan did not plan to take that risk.

From another angle, this faint sense of rejection might also be reminding him that these stars were not all the same.

When he first took over the body of that “sacrificial victim”, he had not felt any rejection. There had been no rejection when he took over the body of the newly dead cultist Ron, either. So why did this repelling force appear around Vanna’s starlight now?

Was it because she was still “alive”? Was it because a living mind would instinctively resist indescribable corruption? Or was it because of… the protection given by faith and divine grace?

Duncan stepped back a bit. While he thought about what these stars meant, he reached slowly toward another cluster of starlight that was closest to him.

He stopped at the last moment before touching that starlight.

There was no repelling force.

Then he tried many times around him. None of those stars pushed him away when he drew near. In some of them, he even faintly felt some new… “elements”.

He felt a vivid sense of life, and even sensed those stars trembling and shrinking in instinctive fear. That was life drawing back when it faced the Shadows of an irresistible death.

Duncan returned to a part of the darkness where the starlight could not reach and looked down at his own hands.

Strands of emerald flame moved through the dark, tracing out illusions of light between his fingers.

It seemed that as he walked the Spirit Realm more and more often, his control and perception of the flames had grown sharper and more precise. Now he could actually sense the presence of life inside those stars.

Duncan frowned slightly and looked toward the far reaches of the endless darkness. The countless points of light stretched densely through the chaotic dark. The sight was almost grand.

Out of caution, he had never explored the far parts of this dark space. But just by looking at how vast the starlight was, he could imagine how many light points there really were here.

At the start, he had thought that all the stars here stood for “corpses” that had just died and met certain conditions, because the first two times he “attached” to someone, he had taken over corpses. But now he felt the presence of life in some of the stars. That meant his first guess was wrong.

Among these stars were not only the dead but also the living. He had simply happened to take over two corpses at first.

The “Inquisitor” named Vanna was also among these stars, and she was without a doubt alive.

Could it be that the countless stars here represented all the living and the dead in the whole world?

Duncan frowned in the dark. The guess rose naturally in his mind and seemed reasonable enough, but he quickly shook his head. He felt he could not jump to a conclusion so fast.

There were many stars here, and the population of this world was far smaller than Earth's. Even so, the stars he could see at a glance still did not seem enough to match the whole world's people. And it was one thing to count the living. How was anyone supposed to define the number of the dead?

Did it include every dead person since ancient times? Or only those whose bodies still remained? Did any body remnant count, or did the time since death have to be within a certain limit?

Besides, there were also clusters of light like the "White Oak" here… Even a ship could show a matching projection here. How was that supposed to be explained?

So it was still too early to rashly treat the starlight here as "all the living and the dead in the world". At the very least, he needed enough proof before he could make such a claim.

But no matter how the stars here tied back to the Mortal Realm, one thing was clear: most of the starlight did not resist Duncan when he drew near. Only Vanna, this "Saint", showed this kind of self-protective response.

That was probably the work of the God she worshiped.

Duncan felt a little curious about the power of "faith" in this world.

But no matter how strong the shield Vanna had built through faith was, it clearly had a flaw. That barrier had not stopped the captain of the Vanished and her from forming a kind of hidden link on the deep layers.

That left only one question: when and how had this link been formed?

Duncan thought hard in the darkness, thinking about what connection he could have with that Inquisitor he had never met and why such a link had appeared out of nowhere. After he ruled out one guess after another, a very bold thought suddenly rose in his mind—

Could it be that it came from the very first “sacrificial victim” he had possessed?!

Duncan recalled the first time he set foot on the land of the city-state of Pland. He thought back to that Sun sacrificial rite. He had caused chaos at the ceremony in the role of the sacrificial victim and then left the “body” he had possessed behind at the scene. Not long after that, Inquisitor Vanna had led a raid on the cultists’ stronghold, captured the cultists who had stayed at the scene, and had surely taken part in cleaning up the “remains” there.

If he had to say so, the only “intersection” between him and that Inquisitor, that young lady, could only have happened then.

All they shared was a body he had once possessed and a place where they had once both been present.

“That alone… was enough to create a link?!” The more Duncan thought about it, the more possible it seemed. He lowered his head in surprise and looked at his own hands. After a while, his shocked expression turned into a very strange, helpless smile. “What kind of space-time fellow traveler infection route is this supposed to be…”

Chapter 108: The Illusory Sun

Duncan was starting to understand why people in the world feared and hated the Vanished so much, and why they treated the captain of the Vanished like a walking plague.

Because in a way, this moving calamity really was like a plague.

In a dark, chaotic space, Duncan quietly turned his gaze on the little flames jumping between his hands, feeling the power hidden inside this fire that acted so gentle toward him.

Fire was the most special thing in this world. It was not only the bearer of light and warmth; it also protected mortal civilization so it could grow in a world full of danger. It kept the balance between the supernatural domain and the Mortal Realm, and it symbolized the Gods' divine blessing and protection over the mortal world.

In almost every field that involved the supernatural, "fire" held a special place and role.

But his fire seemed to carry some faint yet extremely dangerous… traits. Even among the supernatural, it was more terrifying than any other flame.

It held extreme corruption, extreme secrecy, and an extreme power to seize and to profane.

From what he knew for now, the spirit form fire already had the power to corrupt and twist supernatural objects. It could also be used to occupy the bodies of the dead, and it could hide inside the souls of the living. Even the

Saint’s power could not fully purge it. As long as the right moment came, the fire would smolder inside the soul and build a secret path leading to the Vanished.

This was basically a plague that was almost impossible to detect or wipe out. At least for now, the so?called power of the Saint seemed to do nothing against this kind of flame.

Duncan let out a soft breath.

He still did not know what use this faint link between him and Vanna could have. But at least for now, it seemed that as long as there was a suitable “medium” and some kind of “trigger”, he could directly see and hear what was happening around that Saint. From what he had sensed earlier by the “mirror”, he should also be able to project his own power to some extent to the Saint’s surroundings—the most effective way would be to corrupt the “fire” near the Saint.

When the passage formed, he clearly sensed that there was “fire” beside Vanna, and that fire was responding to his gaze. Together with the experience he had gained while controlling the spirit form fire before, he could be sure that “fire” had to be one of the conditions for building the link.

As for what exactly counted as a suitable “medium” and “trigger”… for the first, he could at least be sure for now that “mirrors” and “fire” could act as carriers for the projection channel—in the “technical” terms of the supernatural field, they were “ritual tools”. As for the second…

Duncan recalled the words he had heard when the link had suddenly formed:

“…it might instead connect them to the Vanished…”

Right after hearing that sentence, he had sensed the passage form. So the trigger was probably hidden in those words.

“The word ‘Vanished’…”

Duncan’s understanding of the supernatural field was limited, but even with what little he knew, he understood how special “names” were in the supernatural.

The name Duncan Abnomar, and the name “the Vanished”, both carried power.

He had, for the moment, a rough answer in his heart:

When Vanna, this “carrier”, spoke the name “the Vanished” near fire and a mirror, the link between her and the Vanished would be strengthened at once. If, at that moment, Duncan then took the initiative to answer that “call” from his side, the passage would form.

As his thoughts slowly calmed down, Duncan also drew back his gaze from the distant “stars”.

He bore no grudge against the Deep Sea Church, and he had no malice at all toward that young inquisitor lady. Naturally, he did not plan to use this link to harm her. But if this connection could now and then bring him some useful information… that would not be a bad thing.

The dark, chaotic space and the scattered lights faded like flowing water. Duncan opened his eyes and saw that he had “returned” to his own cabin.

The Golden Sun Mask, made in imitation of the Sun, lay quietly at his hand. The pigeon AI was crouched on the table near the mask, dozing.

Earlier, he had sent the bird off to chat with Goathead, but for some reason Goathead had not wanted to talk and had sent the bird right back.

After a brief hesitation, Duncan reached out and picked up that Sun mask.

Although there had been a few small accidents and he had somehow run into a lot of unexpected information, things had finally gone back on track —he now had time to study this “Sun sacred relic”.

He first turned the mask over a few times, checking the details of its shape and the exact material it was made of. While he was doing that, he suddenly noticed that one corner of the mask seemed to have been chipped.

From that chipped spot, a dull, murky color faintly showed through.

Duncan frowned. The next second, the pigeon that had been napping on the table suddenly opened its eyes. It flapped its wings, hopped around, and squawked: “Iron plated with copper! Iron plated with copper!”

When Duncan heard the pigeon, the chipped part of the mask looked even more glaring to him. He quickly scratched at the damaged spot with his fingernail and studied it for a while. At last, with a blank look, he reached a conclusion—

It really was damned iron plated with copper, not even gold?plated.

Some spots on the corner of the mask had even started to turn green…

“Isn’t this just cheating people!”

The gap between what he had expected and what he had found finally made Duncan mutter out loud. He stared, very depressed, at the heavy lump of iron in his hand and thought of the “resell” plan he had had before he started studying the mask. His heart felt icy. “I was counting on squeezing a few more layers of profit out of those cultists… even a mass?produced sacred relic shouldn’t be made like this, right?!”

The pigeon AI rolled its eyes at his grumbling, flapped its wings, and squawked: “Can you even guarantee your melons are ripe?”

It took Duncan a moment to get what the pigeon meant—it was basically asking, “Are all the goods in your shop actually genuine?”

He thought about the pile of defective modern industrial products back in his shop, looked at AI with a blank face, and said: “Shut up.”

After that, he ignored the annoying bird beside him and turned his attention back to the golden mask.

Now that he had confirmed this thing really was a cheap, mass?produced item, he no longer had any worries about his “test”.

A faint green flame rose from his fingertips and flowed like water over the patterns on the surface of the Golden Sun Mask. Under Duncan’s control, it then slowly seeped into the inside of this “sacred relic”.

A mass?produced sacred relic was still a sacred relic. Even if this thing was really just iron plated with copper, the runes carved inside it and the Sun?shaped design on its surface still had to be able to produce an supernatural effect. Since that Sun priest could use it to communicate with his “deity”, it meant this Sun mask could be studied according to the usual rules for supernatural items.

Duncan actually had quite a bit of experience in the field of studying supernatural items. His main method was to set them on fire whenever things did not add up—the most recent example was burning Alice’s coffin box with the green flame. Facts had proven that this research method worked very well.

As he felt the flames gradually invade the inside of the mask, Duncan also focused his mind and began to sense what information might be hidden inside this supernatural item.

This was a mass?produced piece, and its “rank” was definitely far below Alice’s doll spirit coffin. Duncan believed he would soon figure out how

this thing worked and what it could do, then corrupt it in reverse and usurp it for himself.

With that thought in mind, he probed into the truth hidden deep inside the mask—yet in the very next second, things went far beyond his expectations.

A blast like roaring thunder suddenly exploded in his mind, as if a passage had been blown open inside the depths of this seemingly ordinary mask. His spirit, which had sunk into the mask, suddenly felt a vast, scorching power spill out everywhere. Right after that, he felt as if he had “passed through” a tunnel, or pushed open a great door, and grand, magnificent visions flooded into his mind!

It might have lasted only a second, maybe even less. It was just a few flashing images—in those images, he saw a blazing fireball burning fiercely, hanging alone in the dark void of space.

The Sun—a true, burning star, pouring out a vast gravity…

In that shocking heat and rending gravity, Duncan faced the scorching of that fierce sun directly. Yet he did not turn to ash in the Sun. That star seemed to be only a phantom from ages long past. It kept the majesty and presence it had once truly possessed, but it could no longer really affect the Mortal Realm at all.

Duncan could only stare in shock, his gaze fixed on this blazing sun burning in illusion, and then watched as it slowly turned by a small angle in his sight.

On the far side of the Sun lay dim, pale flesh and countless curled, withered tendrils. Those hateful limbs, stretching for millions of kilometers, all crowded around a half?open, half?shut, gigantic eye that had been dead and decaying for who knew how many ages.

The burning corona blazed on a false shell woven and held up by that flesh and those tendrils—releasing a power that tried its best to imitate the Sun, yet was, in the end, only a replica.

A faint, drifting voice, almost like a hallucination, sounded by Duncan's ear:

"Flame Usurper… extinguish me… please…"

Chapter 109: Flame Usurper

A violent feeling of falling came out of nowhere and tore Duncan's spirit away from the blazing sun. He felt as if a powerful gravity were dragging him through a deep, long tunnel. The burning corona and the flesh that held it up rushed away from his sight. The next second, he felt a solid pressure against his back.

It was the back of his chair.

Duncan snapped his eyes open and gasped for breath. He felt his heart beating harder than it ever had. On his retinas, it was as if there was still a blinding light left behind by that burning star.

The truth of the flesh beneath that sea of fire was etched even more sharply into his mind.

After a few more seconds, these strong impressions slowly faded in his mind, and only that one vague sentence still echoed in the depths of his memory—

"Flame Usurper, extinguish me, please…"

Duncan frowned slightly. He was sure he had really heard those words.

Was that… sent to him by that "Sun"? Had that thing sensed his spying and then sent him this… signal that sounded like a plea for help?

Duncan rubbed his forehead. While he guessed at the truth behind this "help" signal, he went over the details of that blazing sun again in his mind.

There was no doubt that this was what the followers of the “ancient true Sun” worshiped—the “true Sun” they talked about.

To be honest, in that brief moment when he first saw it, Duncan had really felt a surge of emotion. The sea of fire of that blazing sun had shocked him so much that he almost thought he was truly seeing the “Sun” from his own memories and understanding, the very star he had once seen from Earth…

The more stirred up he had been then, the more stunned and lost he had felt after seeing the truth on the far side of the Sun.

The front of that Sun really was exactly the same as the “real Sun”, completely matching what the Suntists had described. But that sight was only the outer shell of the Sun. Inside it… was nothing but an unnameable mass.

Duncan recalled that pale, murky flesh and the shriveled, decaying state of the tendrils that crowded around the eye.

The “creature” wrapped inside the shell of the Sun did not seem to be in good shape.

In fact, Duncan even thought it was already “dead”—the feeling of lost life was so strong that even from far away, just peeking at it, he could feel that breath of “death” rush at him from the depths of his soul.

It was basically the burning corpse of an Elder God.

And that corpse of an Elder God was asking him for help, hoping someone would come and extinguish the flames on its body.

A corpse crying for help—this was both contradictory and horrifying, bizarre beyond reason, yet it still fit the already twisted “logic” of this world.

Duncan slowly sorted out his tangled thoughts and remembered that, during that brief glimpse, there had been another very striking detail: the way that “Sun” had addressed him—it had called him “Flame Usurper”.

Was that unnameable mass of flesh really calling out to him? Had it truly sensed the approach of this uninvited guest and spoken because of that? Was it really not just shouting blindly in a haze?

If that plea really had been meant for him, then this was a very clear form of address—Flame Usurper…

Duncan lowered his head and rubbed his fingertips together, watching a small flame burn quietly there.

The green spirit form fire waited obediently for his command, ready to corrupt other flames and seize the power of other anomalies.

A second later, Duncan dispelled the spirit form fire in his hand.

Whether that “Sun” had really been speaking to him or not, and whatever exactly “Flame Usurper” was supposed to mean, none of it was something he could deal with right now. The cultists in the city?state of Pland were still hiding in the shadows. He neither had the ability nor the standing to deal with the “Sun god” behind them.

Besides, how was he supposed to “help” that burning Sun? Use this little bit of spirit form fire of his to burn over that whole giant mass? He would burn himself out long before he finished! And anyway, just because the thing had asked him for help did not mean it was “on his side”—who knew what would happen if that Sun were extinguished? What if the flames were actually a seal, and once they went out, the unnameable thing inside the Sun would wake up and go on a rampage? Would it still remember the favor of him “putting out the fire” then?

It was never a wise idea to casually deal with something that was basically a deity.

Duncan shook his head, feeling only a bit of sighing in his heart—the so?called “Sun god” really was not the Sun he knew.

Maybe, in this world, he really would never see true sunlight again.

The Golden Sun Mask, made in the shape of the Sun, still lay quietly on the table. The shine on its surface had grown dull, as if the energy inside it had already been used up.

Duncan reached out, wanting to pick up the mask, but the moment his fingertips touched it, a faint cracking sound reached his ears.

The mask, which had been very solid iron (plated with copper), suddenly seemed as if it had gone through millions of years of weathering and decay. In the next second it turned to dust in his hand and scattered away on the air.

AI hopped over, flapping, and spread its wings in front of Duncan as it gestured: “Happy, pop, all gone!”

Duncan paid no attention to the bird begging to be smacked. A faint understanding rose in his heart—

This mask was, in the end, only a mass?produced sacred relic made as an imitation. Those Suntists seemed to be best at using all kinds of rituals to make this kind of limited?effect replica. These replicas had a bit of the power of a real item, but their lifespan was always worrying.

The function of the Sun mask was probably to act as some kind of communication channel. Lower?ranked priests used it to contact the deity they believed in, or the “spawn” under that deity. Just now, he had forced the mask to unleash all its power with the spirit form fire, letting it briefly have the effect of a genuine item and letting him glimpse the image of the

Sun god through the passage—and those few seconds had directly used up the mask's entire "lifespan".

"Maybe I'll have to find a way to get a real one in the future…" Duncan said thoughtfully as he watched the ashes drifting in the air. "If it takes one of these every three seconds, they really can't stand the burning…"

He did not plan to actually "save" any Sun god, but he was still quite interested in the secrets those Suntists were hiding, and he was full of curiosity about the history before the Great Annihilation. He felt he would keep doing research in the field of the supernatural. The wool on those cultists… still had to be plucked.

But as his research went deeper, he would have to find ways to pluck some higher?quality wool.

After a short rest to recover his strength, Duncan left his cabin.

Goathead, who had been spacing out by the chart table, turned his head at the sound. He first checked to see whether the pigeon had come out with Duncan. Only when he saw that Duncan was alone did he breathe a sigh of relief. "Ah, great Captain, your loyal and—details omitted—servant has been dutifully steering in your stead. I wonder if your latest 'voyage afar' went smoothly? I sensed your soul traveling very far again, but this time it didn't seem to be a human city?state? If you plan to go that far next time, you could actually tell me beforehand…"

"How much do you know about the 'true Sun god' those Suntists believe in?" Duncan waved a hand and asked directly.

After spending some time with Goathead, he had come to understand the other's temperament more and more, and he had grown more confident in his own "captain" identity. When they talked and he asked questions now,

he was no longer as cautious as at the beginning. It felt fine to casually ask some questions that were not directly related to the essence of the Vanished.

It also let him test, while he was at it, just how much this strange Goathead really knew about the supernatural.

“The true Sun god?” Goathead was taken aback for a moment, then spoke with some hesitation. “To be honest, I don’t really know. I only know that the cultists who follow the Sun god are all both mad and foolish, but I don’t know what kind of thing the deity behind them actually is… Still, the Sun god’s ‘divine blessing’ does exist. Those cultists do gain some strange powers once their faith is devout enough. That’s also why this cult could slowly grow.”

As he spoke, Goathead gradually reacted. “Ah, why did you suddenly bring this up? Don’t tell me you just…”

“I was just thinking,” Duncan said slowly, sighing, “if a so?called ‘deity’ is being roasted over a fire by its own believers, and those believers don’t know anything about it, and keep working overtime to throw more wood on the fire every day, while they mistake the ‘corpse oil’ rendered from their deity for the divine blessing that deity has granted them… then the whole thing is a bit ironic. It would be too much even as a joke told in hell.”

The enchanted sea chart room grew quiet. Goathead actually did not pick up the thread of the conversation. This made Duncan glance at him in surprise. “Why aren’t you talking? Aren’t you usually very chatty?”

Goathead spoke in a rather muffled tone. “…This topic is way too terrifying. I don’t dare say anything, and I don’t dare ask anything. I can only say, Captain, your insight is truly impressive…”

Duncan could not help but laugh.

He did not know if it was his imagination, but he was starting to feel that even this Goathead before him did not seem as sinister and dangerous as at the beginning. The atmosphere on this ship… seemed to be slowly getting better?

Chapter 110: What a Coincidence

In the city-state of Pland, inside an antique shop in the Lower City, Duncan sat behind the counter with a copy of the city-state's daily paper in his hands, looking as if he was casually reading it.

Suddenly, he blinked twice. His once-distant gaze came back into focus. He glanced at the newspaper in his hands and calmly turned it right side up.

The front-page headline carried the latest big news in the city-state: His Excellency Bishop Valentine of the Deep Sea Cathedral would soon preside over a large-scale benediction. When that happened, more than ten cathedrals across the entire city would ring their Great Bells and pull their steam whistles, calling on the power of the Storm Goddess to bring a divine blessing down upon the city.

As a prelude to this benediction, Governor Dante Wayne had offered his congratulations to the Deep Sea Cathedral last night and sent a gift…

The front page also printed a portrait of the city-state's Governor. He was a middle-aged man with a stern expression, gray hair, and a tall, thin build. The most striking thing was the scary scar across his face, and a prosthetic eye that had replaced one of his real eyes.

It was clearly the mark of some near-fatal accident.

Duncan let his gaze drift over the paper, but in his mind he saw the face of the young Inquisitor named Vanna. That Inquisitor had a scar near her eye as well. It did not affect her sight, but it was very noticeable.

He recalled the information he had gathered recently:

The Governor of this city-state, Dante Wayne, was Vanna Wayne's uncle. The scars on their faces were said to come from the same incident. Eleven years ago, there had been a factory leak and a cultist riot in the "Sixth District" near the Crossroad District. Dante Wayne and Vanna Wayne had been wounded by rioters there, leaving them both with permanent scars. That accident also pushed them to become staunch supporters of the Deep Sea Church and to take an active role in fighting cult activity in the city-state…

None of this was secret in the city-state. It could be found in official records and in street gossip. Ask around a little in the Lower City, and this was exactly what people would tell you.

Eleven years ago again. The "factory leak" in the Sixth District again…

Duncan turned the page in silence while he pieced together and sorted all the clues he had been collecting lately in his mind.

The Sun fragment. The great fire in Nina's memories. Nina's recent nightmares. The accident that had struck Inquisitor Vanna and Governor Dante back then. And that mysterious maiden Shirley, who seemed to be investigating the truth herself… All of these things circled around the "factory leak" in the Sixth District eleven years ago. Now the Suntists were stirring again in the city. Behind them, their "Sun god" was something burning, something like an Eldritch God.

That thing was still crying for help.

Duncan did not plan to deal with that Sun god yet, but he worried that this nameless fire smoldering in the dark might spread to Nina.

He had sent the pigeon out early in the morning to search the city-state for traces of cultists, and it was still wandering outside. Nina was upstairs

packing her books and would soon leave for school. The street outside the shop was growing livelier. The sounds of carts and passersby drifted in through the door, bringing a sense of life and energy.

Light footsteps suddenly came from the stairs. The old wooden boards creaked softly. Nina ran into Duncan's field of view, holding her schoolbag in one hand and a piece of bread for lunch in the other: "Uncle! I'm going to school!"

"Slow down. Don't trip. It's still early," Duncan said with a helpless look at the young lady. Then he remembered something. "Right, today is the day you go to the City Museum?"

"Yes! I made plans with a classmate!" Nina turned back, her face bright with a wide smile. "I won't come home for lunch. I'll go straight to the City Museum with my classmate. You can fix something for yourself."

"Got it, got it," Duncan said with a smile, waving his hand. Then he reminded her again: "Slow down, and watch out for the traffic on the road…"

"Okay, okay, goodbye, Uncle!"

With the girl's clear shout, her light footsteps, and the jingle of the bell over the door, Nina's figure vanished from Duncan's sight.

She crossed the road in front of the antique shop and ran quickly into Pland's morning light.

Duncan watched Nina leave and remembered that earlier home visit, and what the old gentleman Morris had told him:

Nina had few friends at school. Most of her classmates did not like to talk to her much.

But even if she had few friends, it seemed there were still one or two classmates who were close to her. Someone was willing to invite her to the City Museum, and she herself looked very happy about it. That was, of course, a good sign.

He had already asked about it yesterday. The classmate going to the City Museum with Nina was a quiet girl who also lived in the Lower City. The two had only become friends recently, but they got along well.

Duncan set down the newspaper in his hands.

Nina had gone to school and would not come back in the afternoon. Today was a workday, and the antique shop probably would not have much business.

Staying here to watch the shop felt like a waste of time. Maybe he could go out into the city, and at the same time… investigate a few things.

Duncan sensed AI's current location in his mind and gave the pigeon the order to "keep patrolling". Then he put on his coat, hung the "closed for a while" sign on the door, locked up the shop, and walked to the nearby station.

There were many people at the station. This was the rush hour when people took the bus to work and school. Duncan blended into the crowd and walked to the signboard beside the stop, studying the route map on it.

His gaze fell on one of the routes. It clearly marked a place: the Sixth District.

That was where the "factory leak" in the official records had happened.

Duncan looked away and waited patiently in the crowd. Buses came and went. Several steam engine buses took away half the people on the platform. After a long time, he finally saw an old bus sway toward them

from the end of the road. The number plate on its front showed it was the one he was waiting for.

Duncan squeezed onto the bus with a large crowd.

The old bus was packed. citizens hurrying to work filled every seat and every bit of standing room in the aisle. Duncan silently squeezed his way to a spot near the back door and waited patiently for the bus to start.

With the hoarse, straining growl of the steam engine, the badly overloaded bus started moving. The conductor began to struggle through the crowd of people packed like sardines, calling for people to buy tickets as he squeezed his way toward Duncan. His dark blue uniform was so crushed it was going out of shape.

“Sixth District,” Duncan said to the conductor with a friendly smile.

But the conductor, dizzy from being squeezed on all sides, froze for a moment when he heard Duncan. It was as if he had not processed it. “Huh? Where are you going?” he asked.

Duncan frowned: “The Sixth District—I saw it on the route map. Doesn’t this bus go there?”

The conductor froze again. Then he looked up at the route map posted on the side of the carriage. It was only then that he seemed to wake up and hurriedly nodded. “Oh, oh, of course it goes there. Hardly anyone goes to that place usually. I almost forgot… Four pesos.”

Hardly anyone went to the Sixth District? The accident had been eleven years ago. Had the area around that factory still not been rebuilt?

A hint of doubt rose in Duncan’s heart, but he bought the ticket without showing anything. Then he watched the conductor push back into the crush of bodies like a warrior charging through thousands of men.

After that, all he could do was quietly wait for the bus to reach his stop.

But just then, he suddenly felt a gaze from nearby.

That look was very brief, as if someone had only brushed their eyes over him by accident before turning away at once. But Duncan's sense for anomalies was sharp. He could feel that the gaze had truly been fixed on him. When it shifted away, he even faintly sensed… fear and a wish to hide. That made him follow the feeling in his heart and look in that direction.

In the next second, he saw a small figure in the crowd of passengers at the back of the bus, trying hard to shrink away.

He saw the figure, and the figure saw him. The person froze at once and stood rigid on the spot, as if she no longer even dared to try to hide.

It was a girl in a black dress, about the same age as Nina by the look of her. Around her neck was a strange collar, and a small bell hung from it…

It was Shirley.

Duncan raised his eyebrows at once. He had not expected things to turn out such a coincidence. Then he began to squeeze his way toward the girl. By now she was completely stiff, staring at Duncan as he came over, her face full of nerves and even fear. She did not just stop trying to dodge. She did not even dare to turn her head.

Duncan slowly came to a stop in front of her and greeted the girl with a smile: "We meet again—are you on your way to school at this hour?"

Shirley forced herself to squeeze out a smile. She had once bragged in front of Dog that she was going to cling to this big boss's thigh, but now that she had realized how terrifying Duncan really was, her smile looked worse than crying: "S…sir… hello…"

Chapter 111: The big boss's Lecture

During the morning rush, the bus was packed. Even near the back there was hardly any space. The short Shirley was squeezed into the crowd, her neck hunched as she held herself still, looking like a pitiful little animal.

If Duncan had not seen with his own eyes how she had swung a dog around and smashed a whole room full of cultists, he might really have believed this young lady was harmless.

He slowly squeezed to Shirley's side. His tall adult frame won a slightly looser corner for the girl and opened a small space where the two of them could talk. Duncan noticed keenly that Shirley was trembling a little. She was very nervous, nervous enough that it had turned into fear.

"What are you afraid of?" He glanced at Shirley. "I'm not going to swallow you whole."

Shirley pulled a long face: "S…sir, are you going to cook me first?"

Duncan: "…"

He could more or less guess why the girl was so afraid. Earlier, that "Dog" had seen some of the "truth" hidden beneath this human body of his. After escaping, the hound had surely added all kinds of details when describing its feelings to its mistress. That must have left a deep impression on her.

He did not know exactly what image he now had in Shirley's mind, but it was probably about the same way the captains on the Boundless Sea saw

the Vanished. Once you met one, the best thing to do was start writing your will at once—and write fast, because you were likely to die before you even finished…

Duncan felt helpless about this. He did try to act as friendly as he could, but he could not change the fact that a demon from the Abyssal Deep of the Deep Sea had a very different kind of "sight" than humans. That "Black Sun" had even begged him for help in a vision, sounding quite sincere. Yet when he thought about the appearance hidden beneath that corona shell, did he not still feel wary himself?

He could only hope that, in the eyes of that Abyssal Hound, he looked a little better than the eerie Eldritch God inside the Sun that he himself had seen—at least enough to have proper facial features…

Thinking of that Abyssal Hound, Duncan frowned slightly and looked at the girl in front of him: "Is Dog with you right now?"

"A…Dog usually hides in places other people can't see…" Shirley swallowed hard and answered, not daring to refuse. Then she lowered her voice. "But it can 'know' what's happening around me…"

"Oh, then give it my regards," Duncan said with a nod. "We parted in a rush last time. I still have many questions I didn't get to ask."

As soon as he said that, he felt Shirley shiver again…

"Relax," Duncan said with a helpless sigh. He could already faintly sense some strange looks turning their way. "Why are you so tense just talking to me? I have no ill will toward you or Dog."

"Th…that's really good…" Shirley nodded stiffly. Then, as if she wanted to prove she was relaxed, she struggled to find a topic for a long moment before her eyes landed on Duncan's shoulder. "Y…you didn't bring your pigeon this time?"

“Pets aren’t allowed on the bus,” Duncan said casually. “I let it out to go hunting.”

“You let a pigeon… go hunting?” Shirley stared at Duncan with wide eyes, feeling as if her words were falling apart. But she quickly nodded. “Right, you’re right. Pigeons are good for hunting. Sharp eyes, fast flight…”

Her thoughts were a bit of a mess, and she was close to losing track of what she was saying. Just then the bus suddenly jolted, and the conductor’s voice came from the middle of the carriage, cutting off her broken train of thought: “Sixth District! Anyone getting off?”

When she heard the shout, Shirley clearly let out a breath of relief. As if she had been rescued, she began hopping as she called out that she was getting off. At the same time she squeezed forward and, with oddly fluent speech, said goodbye to Duncan: “I’m getting off. It was very nice to see you today. Next time we’ll…”

Before she could finish, she saw Duncan squeezing forward as well. The bright look on her face turned dull in an instant.

“I’m getting off at this stop too,” Duncan said with a blank face.

Shirley’s face went stiff. She knew it would be strange to say she was not getting off now. Besides, this big boss might be following her on purpose. If she kept trying tricks at this point, she might anger him, and then he really would cook her and eat her…

The girl’s imagination ran wild, and she ended up scaring herself quite badly. Just then she heard the conductor urging her from the side, so she shrank her neck again and started walking toward the door with stiff steps.

When she had just reached the door, the conductor’s voice suddenly came: “Wait a second, child. Did you not buy a ticket?”

Shirley froze and stared in surprise at the conductor in the dark blue uniform, as if it had never occurred to her that someone would call her out, or that her fare-dodging would be noticed. In that brief daze, the conductor had already confirmed it. “You didn’t buy a ticket. I remember now. First you…”

“I know this child. She probably just lost her ticket,” Duncan’s voice suddenly came from the side. “I’ll buy another one for her.”

The conductor turned his head and gave Duncan a doubtful look, then glanced at Shirley’s tense face. After thinking for a moment, he said nothing more and only nodded. “All right then.”

Duncan took out a few coins to buy a ticket for Shirley, then followed her out of the carriage. They got off beside an old, empty platform.

The bus was packed with passengers, but only the two of them got off in the Sixth District.

Duncan first looked around at the surroundings. All he saw was the most ordinary kind of Lower City neighborhood. The buildings around them were old, and there were not many people walking near the station, but it was far from the total ruin he had imagined. The worn shopfronts along the street were open for business as usual. The scattered pedestrians were fewer than in livelier districts, but there were still always a few people walking along the road. In the distance, factory chimneys spewed smoke, and he could see a newsboy on a bicycle passing through a junction at the end of the street.

Overall, this was just a quieter, less developed district, but the residents seemed to be living their lives as normal.

The factory leak here eleven years ago had clearly left some traces, but the impact was not as serious as he had imagined…

After roughly taking in the situation around them, Duncan withdrew his gaze and turned it back to Shirley.

After getting off, the girl had stood obediently in place, like a small animal caught in a trap, not moving at all. Even though Duncan's attention had not been on her at first, she had made no attempt to run.

She looked completely ready to let fate decide what happened.

Seeing how meek and harmless she looked, Duncan could not help but feel amused. If he had not seen this hot-tempered girl's fierce fighting with his own eyes, he might really have been fooled by her act.

He shook his head and walked up to Shirley. "What are you doing in the Sixth District?"

Shirley straightened up at once. "I…I heard the scenery here is nice!"

Duncan looked her up and down. "I've wanted to ask since just now. Are you… pretending to be obedient?"

"I…I'm not pretending!" Shirley stood even straighter than before. "I'm always very obedient!"

Duncan shook his head. He had seen plenty of children suddenly pretend to be sweet and cute like this, and this young lady's act was not even very good. But he did not say more. He only lifted his head to glance at the distant street and spoke in a casual tone: "The Sixth District… Eleven years ago, there was a factory leak here, and they say cultists were behind the accident."

Shirley blinked, looking confused. "Why are you bringing that up all of a sudden?"

"Enough, don't play dumb. You were asking about what happened eleven years ago at the Suntists' hideout," Duncan said, giving Shirley a look as he

started walking forward. “This place is the focus of all the official records. The factory where the ‘leak’ happened is just up ahead.”

Shirley froze for a moment, then hurried to follow, her short legs moving quickly as she looked at Duncan in surprise. “Are you… also investigating the accident from eleven years ago?!”

After she confirmed that the big boss really did not eat people—at least not for now—and that they had the same goal, her courage grew a little. She even dared to ask questions on her own now.

“Yes, I’m a bit interested,” Duncan said, neither fully admitting nor denying it. But after only a few steps he suddenly stopped again and looked at Shirley curiously. “Do you often ride without paying?”

Shirley opened her mouth. “I…”

One look at the girl’s face told Duncan the answer. He shook his head. “Fare-dodging is bad.”

Shirley almost burst into tears when she heard that. Dog had lectured her. The uncles and aunties in the neighborhood had lectured her. Even the city-state’s constable had lectured her. But she had truly never thought that one day she would be suddenly lectured by a big boss on the level of an Eldritch God—and that this kind of big boss would lecture her about not riding the bus without paying… Had the moral standards of the big bosses in Subspace really grown this high these days?!

Ever since Dog had described the terrifying being inside this “Mr. Duncan” to her last time, she had faintly started to link this big shot with the Shadows in Subspace.

Chapter 112: Run-Down District

Shirley followed carefully at Duncan's side. The temporary quiet didn't relax her; it only made her feel more of a suffocating fear frozen inside the silence. She knew the fear wasn't entirely her own. Most of it came from "Dog".

Dog was feeling afraid, and its emotions spread over to her through the shackles of the symbiotic pact.

To ease the pressure in that silence, she muttered under her breath: "I never used to get caught when I skipped fares… Dog always helped cover for me…"

"You mean that 'disguise' the Abyssal Hound gave you?" Duncan raised an eyebrow. He remembered that Shirley had slipped into a Cult den before by relying on some kind of disguise power from Dog, a sort of cognitive interference. But he soon shook his head: "It doesn't feel reliable at all. Last time they saw through it, and this time even a ticket seller caught you."

As soon as Shirley heard that, she swallowed a bellyful of complaints. Dog's disguise hadn't failed at all! They had only been exposed because some terrifying being's gaze wiped it out. Was it really proper for a big shot like that to play this kind of joke on her…

But she didn't dare say any of that out loud. After holding it in for a long time, it turned into a dry laugh: "Ah-haha… you're right, you're right…"

Duncan shook his head. He didn't care what was going on in Shirley's mind. He was only a bit curious about what this girl was investigating:

“Why are you so focused on that ‘accident’ from eleven years ago?”

Shirley fell silent at once. She seemed to instinctively not want to answer that kind of question. But then she pressed her lips together, as if realizing that hiding something like this in front of a being almost like a Subspace Shadow was meaningless. She spoke in a low voice: “It’s nothing much. I just want to figure out… what really happened to my parents…”

After she said it, she hurried to add: “Someone like you must think this kind of thing is boring. I know, our mortal obsession with family must look…”

“No, I understand,” Duncan cut her off before the young lady could start rambling. He could guess well enough what he looked like in Shirley’s eyes, and anything she said next would be full of flattery and nonsense. “That really is a very important reason.”

As he spoke, he looked at Shirley. His gaze became more serious: “Were your parents caught up in that ‘leak’ eleven years ago? Or were they attacked by cultists?”

Shirley looked at Duncan in some surprise. She didn’t quite understand why this big shot, who clearly did not live or work like normal people, cared so much about such things. But she still nodded honestly: “They… disappeared eleven years ago. Fine, calling it ‘disappeared’ is a bit dramatic. They died. But they died without any clear cause… and after that, it was just me and Dog relying on each other…”

The girl’s voice grew a little low. These memories were not pleasant for her. Duncan did not let her go on: “How did you meet Dog? Those Suntists said you were a believer of the Cult of Annihilation, and that only Annihilation believers can summon Abyssal demons. But you don’t seem to accept that.”

“I don’t believe in any ‘cult’! The only damned one I believe in is myself!” Shirley blurted out. Then she quickly lowered her voice and tried to look

well-mannered and polite. “Dog and I… met eleven years ago.”

Duncan suddenly stopped walking and fixed his eyes on Shirley: “Eleven years ago? So…”

“Right after that so-called ‘factory leak’,” Shirley also stopped and lowered her head as she explained. “I don’t remember the details. Dog says it doesn’t remember either… It was probably summoned by some Annihilation believer, but whoever summoned it must have been killed by a guardian of the Deep Sea Church. Then, for some reason, it just ended up ‘bound’ to me…”

Shirley hid a lot. In that vague and brief account, far too many details were skipped.

Duncan could feel the girl’s evasions and omissions, but he did not mind too much.

It was a very normal kind of self?protection. Even when facing an overwhelming being she could not resist, she still instinctively tried to avoid laying her entire past bare.

He could probably threaten Shirley into telling him more, but that might not bring out the whole truth. Besides, there was still not even basic trust between him and the girl, so this topic could end here for now.

Duncan shook his head and looked at the slightly run?down streets on both sides, and at the passersby who moved more slowly and lazily than people in other districts. He sighed softly: “…I hardly see any children. Everyone on the street is either old or middle?aged. There aren’t many young people either.”

“Old districts are all like this,” Shirley said, as if it was only natural. She sounded like she knew what she was talking about. “Anyone who can manage it moves to the Crossroad District. The ones who can’t move are

either the elderly or people just muddling along. And a place like this could never have a neighborhood school, so of course children won't stay. They all go off with the adults…"

Listening to Shirley's serious-sounding analysis, Duncan only gave a noncommittal grunt.

He could imagine how old neighborhoods like this tended to age, but even so, the lifeless mood on these streets still felt a bit too strange.

While he was thinking, Duncan noticed an old man with graying hair sitting in front of a shop by the street. The man seemed to be basking in the sun, but when he noticed the unfamiliar faces on the road, he turned a somewhat dazed and puzzled gaze toward them.

Duncan led Shirley straight over.

"Good morning," Duncan greeted the old man sitting in the doorway in the sun. "We're from the Fourth District and wanted to ask… how do we get to the cathedral?"

He didn't actually care where the cathedral was. He had just picked a random excuse to strike up a conversation with a local.

"The cathedral? The cathedral isn't open these days. Who knows where that nun went off to," the old man in the sun roused himself a little from his laziness and sat up, looking curiously at the strangers before him. "How strange. We hardly ever get outsiders who want to come here… What are you here for?"

"Visiting a friend," Duncan said casually. "People usually don't like coming here? Why?"

"All because of that damned factory," the old man complained angrily. He clearly wasn't happy with how desolate the district had become. "How many years has it been? The area around the factory is still a ruined

wasteland where nothing grows. Everyone says the chemicals from that leak back then were never really cleaned up. People from the nearby districts even go the long way around when they pass by. Who would dare come close to this place…”

Duncan and Shirley exchanged a look. Then he asked: “I saw an old newspaper that said the area around the factory had already been cleaned up…”

“The newspapers… the newspapers talk about good news all the time! The paper also said the new governor would revive the western industrial zone!” The old man spat to the side. “And what happened? The West Side gets worse every day, and our old factory is still a pile of ruins. Let me tell you, when that factory was still running this place was great. Back then, the Sixth District was one of the richest neighborhoods in the whole Lower City. Now look at this mess…”

Once the old man started complaining, he went on and on. It was rare to have strangers around to listen, and the laziness he’d had while sunbathing vanished without a trace. Seeing this, Duncan quickly cut in: “By the way, I noticed there aren’t many children around here… and not many young people either. Did they all move away?”

“Move? Nobody moves from here. However shabby this place is, at least everyone still has their old houses. Do you think they can just afford the rent in other districts?” The old man shook his head. “There aren’t many young people because the young ones have grown old. As for children… tch…”

The old man suddenly let out a sigh.

“There hasn’t been a single child born here in eleven years!”

“No newborns in eleven years?!” Duncan finally widened his eyes a little. “Really?”

“Would I lie? I’ve lived here most of my life,” the old man said, rolling his eyes. “If you ask me, it’s all the factory’s fault… The land around it is tainted with corruption…”

Duncan said nothing. He slowly straightened up and looked toward the end of the district, toward the spot on the map where he had seen the ruined factory marked.

Beside him, Shirley was still chatting curiously with the old man. She asked about the factory, about the residents who had stayed in the Sixth District, and about how many people had moved away over the past eleven years.

However, the old man seemed to have lost his patience. He waved his hand irritably and muttered more complaints, brushing off most of Shirley’s questions.

“Let’s go,” Duncan suddenly said to Shirley, diverting her attention before the hot?tempered girl could flare up. Then he glanced at the old man, who had gone back to basking in the sun, and gave a slight nod. “Thank you.”

“Oh, you’re welcome,” the old man waved a hand. “Take care.”

Chapter 113: Searching for a Great Fire

Walking down the road, Shirley looked rather annoyed: “Why wouldn’t that old man answer my questions! He acted like he didn’t hear me at all when I talked to him… Is being short really that easy to ignore?!”

“I don’t think your height is the main reason. It’s because you kept chasing him about the factory,” Duncan tilted his head slightly and glanced at the girl. “And instead of wasting time on a local who doesn’t want to cooperate, wouldn’t it be better to go and see the factory with our own eyes?”

Shirley pressed her lips together and said no more. Ahead of her and Duncan, at the end of the street, they could already faintly see the factory that had been abandoned eleven years ago.

In the Lower City, many factories stood close to residential areas, sometimes only a single wall away from where people lived. The limited land within the city?state and the blockade of the Boundless Sea meant the city planners could not spare enough ground for separate industrial zones. Every piece of solid ground was crowded with people. There was no such thing as “moving industry out” or “a plant in the suburbs”.

Most people in this world had no time to worry about the health risks of industrial pollution. For the general public, the safety that modern technology brought to the city?state was far more important than the dangers of the factories. Gas lamps, heavy firepower, the Steam Grid, potions and mechanical ships — these things had made the population of

the new Age of City?States nearly three times that of the Old Era. Anyone who understood how a modern city?state worked could see one fact clearly: factories were the bones and flesh of modern civilization. They could no longer be separated from the city?state.

In fact, as Nina's textbooks described, these industrial facilities were not only gathered in the Lower City. City planners tried their best to move the most dangerous ones toward the outer edges of the city?state, but some things still had to be placed in its very heart, even right beside the great cathedral. There was the sacred Great Bell tower, and the "central steam core" that sent Holy Gas through pipes to the entire city.

All of these were, at their core, enormous machines. They held terrible power and great risk, yet they still had to stand beside the city's heart.

In Nina's engineering and mechanics textbooks, the writers even gave a special explanation for this.

People had to "grant sanctity to the holy steam" and "rely on the power of the great cathedral to keep the bell tower's timing in order". Machines were not only machines. They were also pure, sacred hearts that kept modern civilization running. People had to place these pure engines of steel under the God's gaze, so that the Shadows of Subspace would not corrupt their oil and bolts.

Duncan recalled what he had read in Nina's textbooks, then looked up at the factory still standing abandoned in the middle of the district. A strange feeling rose in his heart.

This bizarre, absurd world… really did keep testing his view of reality.

He and Shirley reached the factory. A thin perimeter wall, collapsed in many places, was the only barrier between the factory grounds and the surrounding residential blocks. Between the plant and the nearby houses lay

a narrow ring of wasteland. Nothing grew on the barren ground. Only scattered chunks of masonry and long?rusted metal scraps lay there.

No matter how important factories were to the city, no matter how used people had become to living beside them day and night, a factory was still a factory. When these giants went into a runaway state, they still left huge scars in the city.

But in a city?state where every scrap of land was precious, it still struck Duncan as odd that a scar like this had been left “unhealed” for eleven years.

“…Land in a city?state should be valuable,” he said thoughtfully as he stood at the edge of the wasteland, looking at the abandoned workshops ahead. “Leaving this place empty like this… doesn’t make much sense.”

“Didn’t that old man say it already? The corruption here couldn’t be cleaned up…” Shirley didn’t seem to be thinking that deeply. “Some corruption can only fade slowly with time.”

“Maybe…” Duncan shook his head. His gaze moved over the rows of pipes and storage tanks along the edge of the factory grounds as he tried to reconstruct how the accident had once unfolded. He saw several broken lengths of pipe. One tank’s base had collapsed, and the whole vessel had toppled over, crushing part of a nearby building. It looked like the carcass of some huge beast.

From these signs alone, it did look very much like a leak had happened here.

But Duncan still frowned slightly.

The old man sunning himself had said there was still corruption lingering around the factory, and that it had even kept the entire Sixth District from

seeing a single newborn in eleven years. Yet around the factory he saw no warning signs, and no patrols or guards.

Things did not add up. It was not a major anomaly, but these small irrational details were still enough to stir doubt.

“Are we… really going in?” Shirley’s voice sounded at his side. Her expression looked a little tense. “There might really be corruption here…”

“Can’t your Dog give you some advice?” Duncan glanced at Shirley. “This place is deserted. You can let that Abyssal Hound out for some air. And I don’t believe you’re really afraid of whatever ‘corruption’ is here — the tension in your eyes looks a little too fake.”

Shirley dodged Duncan’s gaze. She raised her hand and replied: “Fine, fine… mainly, Dog isn’t in great shape…”

As soon as the girl finished speaking, the crackle of flames suddenly sounded out of thin air beside her. A sheet of pitch?black fire spread along her arm and half her body. The flames gathered into chains, and at the end of the chains, in thick smoke and dark fire, the figure of a Abyssal Hound emerged.

Duncan watched the process with interest. When Dog finally appeared, he smiled and nodded to the Abyssal Hound: “Long time no see, Dog — you ran off pretty quickly last time.”

“We left in a hurry, in a hurry, please don’t hold it against us,” Dog tucked its tail the moment it appeared. When it heard Duncan’s voice, its whole body visibly seemed to shrink by half. It drew in its limbs as much as it could and lowered its skull carefully. “What do you need done? I’m good at all kinds of things. I can fetch plates, sweep the floor, entertain a child, whatever you like…”

Before the Abyssal Hound even finished, Shirley was already covering half her face beside it, clearly thinking: [I've been cowardly enough this whole way, and you still manage to set a new record.] Duncan couldn't help but laugh. He raised a hand and pointed at the factory ahead: "I don't need anything done. I just want to borrow your eyes. You can see things ordinary people can't, can't you? Take a look at that factory and tell me what's wrong with it."

"Listen to you, as if my eyes were worthy of your notice…" Dog flattered him at once, but still turned its head toward the factory as it spoke, muttering, "I've been watching this place since just now and didn't see anything… It still looks the same now, just an abandoned…"

Dog's voice cut off. It suddenly crouched low, a warning growl rumbling in its throat — yet the next second, it shook its skull and made a puzzled sound: "…Huh?"

Seeing this, Shirley tensed at once: "Dog, what did you see?!"

"I… I don't know. For a moment, I think I saw… fire? It looked like a huge fire, surging out of the factory like a giant wave, but… it vanished in the blink of an eye…"

Dog's voice was full of doubt, but Shirley suddenly became excited: "You're sure you saw fire?! A real great fire?!"

Dog shook its massive skull. "It was just a flash. It might have been a hallucination. I am a Abyssal demon after all. Having a hallucination now and then, being a bit unsound in the head, that's normal…"

"But a great fire is different!" Shirley's voice grew urgent. "We've been searching for so long. We finally found traces of 'the fire'. This has to be it, Dog. It must be here…"

Shirley was halfway through her excited words when she felt a large hand rest on her shoulder. Her voice cut off. A delayed sense of tension ran through her as she stiffly turned her head — and saw the terrifying “Mr. Duncan” quietly watching her.

“Why did you react so strongly to ‘the fire’?” Duncan looked into Shirley’s eyes and asked slowly.

“I…” Shirley opened her mouth. “It’s noth—”

“You’re also looking for a ‘great fire’ from eleven years ago, aren’t you?” Duncan did not care about the girl’s attempt to change the subject. Her reaction had already made him think of something. “A fire that doesn’t exist in any official record, but that you experienced yourself. Am I right?”

Shirley’s body went a little rigid. She swallowed slowly. “H?how did you…”

“I’m looking for it too,” Duncan said with a smile. “It seems we’ve come to the right place.”

Chapter 114

In front of the ruined, abandoned factory, the Abyssal Hound Dog raised its hollow eye sockets and fixed its gaze on the collapsed workshop, as if trying to observe this ruin in the Mortal Realm from another dimension.

Shirley stood beside Dog, a little nervous as she looked around. Only after she checked Duncan's expression did she finally lower her voice and ask: "Dog, are you sure there is really no lingering corruption here?"

"If you mean the so called 'chemical leak' in the mouths of ordinary people, you can relax. The corruption here probably faded away years ago…" A hoarse, low voice came from Dog's throat. "But if you mean some kind of corruption from the supernatural side of things… that I cannot guarantee."

"Did you find anything?" Duncan asked from the side.

"…No, really no," Dog lowered his skull a little. "I only saw 'fire' for a brief moment just now. But now it is gone. It may have been some kind of 'after echo'… a memory left and frozen in this ruin. Many supernatural powers leave similar traces in the Mortal Realm. But if we want to figure out what kind of supernatural power it was… we probably have to go in and take a look."

"Then we go in," Duncan said with a nod. He stepped toward a gap in the abandoned factory wall. "You two, follow."

Shirley hesitated for a moment but still walked after him. Dog shook his head left and right, the black chains on him clattering. The Abyssal Hound looked at Duncan's back with cautious curiosity: "You… why are you also

interested in what happened eleven years ago? Ah, of course, I am only asking casually, just a tiny bit of curiosity. A big shot like you must have your own…”

“Just treat it as my personal interest,” Duncan cut the Abyssal Hound off. “You really do not need to be this nervous in front of me. It makes me feel uncomfortable.”

“Alright, alright, we are not nervous, we are not nervous…”

Hearing this reply that sounded very nervous no matter how you listened to it, Duncan could only shake his head helplessly. Then he looked at Shirley beside him with some curiosity: “In your memory, there was a great fire. But except for you, everyone else forgot that it ever happened. Is that right?”

“…Yeah.” Shirley nodded. By now she had already realized something. “From the way you are acting… you also know about that fire, right? That fire really existed, right?”

“Yes, I know,” Duncan nodded slightly and spoke in a calm tone. “So now I am even more curious about who erased the traces of that fire’s existence.”

At the same time, his thoughts churned in his heart. He had not expected things to develop in such a coincidental way, nor that in the city-state of Pland there would be a third person who knew about that “fire” besides himself and Nina. His chance encounter with Shirley, their shared investigation, the fire whose traces had been wiped away, Dog’s illusion just now… all these things seemed to be drawn together by an invisible force, gathering as if planets circling the Sun.

This feeling, of everything being pulled together by a hidden power, already made him very wary.

Nina’s schoolbooks had once given a rough outline of some “common sense” about the supernatural. They mentioned that powerful Anomalies or Visions often had the ability to interfere with the development of the Mortal Realm. They could even guide events like weaving a script, using subtle mental guidance. Too many coincidences in a row, or clues that kept appearing one after another, were often alarming “prophetic visions”.

These signs usually meant that the people involved had already been influenced by some Anomaly or Vision and were unconsciously taking part in, or even pushing forward, the event.

And faced with this kind of invisible yet harmless push and influence, the fire of his spirit form was not of much use.

Thinking of this, he secretly glanced at Shirley.

The girl and Dog were carefully on guard against any movement in the ruined factory. Shirley seemed to have no extra or complicated thoughts at all. Or maybe it was because this “Great Terror” was standing right beside her, leaving her no space to let her mind wander?

“This really looks like just an ordinary ruin…” Dog’s low voice broke Duncan’s thoughts. “I do not sense any trace of supernatural power.”

Shirley raised her head, studying the crisscrossing pipes overhead and the warped beams of the ceiling.

This was the first workshop they entered after coming into the factory. It had been heavily damaged in the accident eleven years ago. Some powerful explosion had blown open the roof, shattered the high pipes, and brought down the building materials. sunlight poured through the huge hole above and spilled into the ruin, making the scene inside look like the jagged bones left behind by a dead giant beast.

However, aside from the blast and the collapse, there was not the slightest trace of a fire in the workshop.

“It doesn’t look like a fire ever happened here…” Shirley muttered under her breath.

“The lack of fire marks is the biggest problem,” Duncan’s deep voice suddenly came from the side. He was also looking up, his gaze on the broken pipes and roof structure. His brows slowly furrowed. “With damage on this level, and with a clear explosion having taken place, there should have been a fire along with it. No matter how big or small, it should at least have left some burned traces in the workshop… yet there is not even a hint that a single spark ever existed here.”

As soon as Duncan finished speaking, Dog answered in a heavy tone: “Yes. The way it looks now, it is like… every element that had anything to do with ‘fire’ was deliberately erased. But because it was erased too cleanly, it actually left a more eye catching blank space instead.”

“Erased…” Duncan whispered. He walked slowly toward the deeper part of the workshop. After he passed a pile of twisted, abandoned machines, he stopped and casually glanced at a hole in the nearby wall.

He suddenly froze, his eyes opening a little wider.

Fire. A towering sea of fire.

He saw waves of blazing flames roaring up from the other side of that hole. Outside the factory, the whole stretch of wasteland was rolling with flames. The blaze rose like a surging ocean, leaping into the air and then crashing down onto the ground. It rushed toward the nearby streets and houses. Thick smoke billowed upward. Countless madly fleeing figures ran through the fire, like a mirage of hell.

This fierce and terrifying scene of burning suddenly broke into Duncan's sight. But in the next second, just as he turned his head, intending to call Shirley over, the image of the burning sea of fire suddenly vanished.

Duncan blinked hard a few times, then walked to the hole in the wall and looked out. All he saw was an empty stretch of wasteland and, at its edge, a few ruined houses that no one lived in anymore.

Dog noticed Duncan's strange behavior at once and asked: "Did you see something?"

"I also saw it just now. Fire," Duncan answered in a low voice. "But when I turned my head, it was gone."

"Then the 'after echo' left here is very strong," Dog quickly judged. "For it to replay twice in such a short time is not a mark an ordinary supernatural power can leave behind. It looks like that group of cultists were right. The 'shard of the Sun' they were looking for really did appear here… we just do not know what triggers the echo…"

Duncan did not reply. He simply walked back to the place where he had first seen the echo and stared thoughtfully at the spot where he had been standing.

It looked as if there was nothing there.

After thinking for a moment, Duncan slowly raised his hand and rubbed his fingertips together.

A tiny, ghostly green flame quietly jumped out from his hand.

The moment that ghostly green flame appeared, Dog's neck shrank at once. Then he quickly retreated three or four steps. The black chains on him rattled. Shirley also followed and backed away half a step, looking at Duncan in horror: "You… you really plan to eat cooked food now?!"

“What are you afraid of?” Duncan looked at this pair without any expression. “This is not for roasting you two.”

As soon as he spoke, he pointed with his fingertip toward the ground.

The ghostly green flame flowed down like a stream and fell silently onto the floor. In the next second, a half transparent fire of spirit form rippled and spread over the ground, sweeping across several meters around Duncan’s feet in an instant.

Shirley watched this scene in growing confusion. Suddenly, her eyes widened. “…Ah!”

Where the flame passed, something appeared on the ground that had been empty before.

It was a patch of ash. A curled, human shaped patch of ash.

It was a human burned into ash. In their final moment, that human had been looking with a rigid gaze toward the same place Duncan had just been staring at.

All at once, something came to Shirley’s mind. She raised her head and looked around the empty factory.

Under Duncan’s deliberate control, the ghostly green fire of spirit form swept across the entire workshop like a gentle breeze.

And so, the erased traces finally reappeared for a brief moment before the eyes of these visitors.

Chapter 115

The ghostly green fire of spirit form floated like a band of light and swept across the whole workshop in a few seconds. This disturbance from a higher supernatural power moved like a wind, lifting the Veil that had been laid over the Mortal Realm, and the truth hidden beneath that Veil appeared before Shirley and Duncan.

Ashes. Ashes everywhere. Human shaped ashes, broken heaps of ashes, walls blackened by smoke, a roof melted by heat. Machines whose shells had been twisted and turned brittle by the licking flames were piled together with lumps of almost shapeless slag. The whole factory zone looked like a fiery purgatory that had only recently cooled. The fire was out, but the power that had melted everything seemed to still linger in the air.

Shirley stood in the middle of the burned ruins, dazed. Her eyes were a little blank. Dog quietly came to her side and used his bony back to gently support her.

Soon, the ghostly green fire of spirit form faded away, and everything in the factory returned to its original state.

Duncan looked at his own hands with a bit of regret. This was, after all, only an “ordinary” body. It could not compare to his true form. The fire of spirit form he could call upon here was limited. When he spread the flames over such a wide range, he could only keep it going for a short while.

But even such a brief “replay” was enough to reveal a crucial truth.

“There really was a great fire… I knew I did not remember wrong…” Shirley muttered to herself. “I have been searching for it for eleven years. It was here all along…”

“But this fire was wiped away,” Dog said softly. “Some power wove a Veil over the Mortal Realm and filtered out every trace connected to ‘fire’… This Veil can even block the sight of Abyssal demons.”

“Was it the shard of the Sun? Or the one who carried the shard into the city-state?” Shirley frowned. Then she noticed that Duncan had been strangely silent for a while and could not help looking at him. “What do you think…”

“This place is still different from the fire scene in my memory,” Duncan shook his head before she could finish. His gaze swept slowly over the factory fittings as he recalled the details he had seen when the Veil was briefly lifted. At the same time, he compared them with the fire in his memory, and with the building and surroundings from when ‘he’ had escaped the fire with Nina. Finally he confirmed his judgment. “This is not the place.”

“Ah?” Shirley was stunned. “The fire in your memory… was not here?”

“The details do not match at all,” Duncan said in a serious tone as he walked slowly toward the factory gate. His eyes passed the fallen door and looked at the ruined street outside. “To be more exact, the scenery of the whole Sixth District… seems wrong.”

Shirley and Dog looked at each other by instinct. She lowered her voice and asked: “What do you think is going on?”

“How would I know? I am only a dog,” Dog shook his skull. “And eleven years ago, I was even more confused than you.”

Duncan heard their voices behind him and turned his head slightly. “Is this factory the only suspicious place?”

“Maybe… probably…” Shirley answered without much confidence. “Anyway, based on what I heard, this factory was the center of the chaos eleven years ago.”

Duncan did not comment. In the next two hours, he, Shirley, and the Abyssal Hound checked every part of the abandoned factory that was still safe enough to enter.

Strangely, apart from that Veil laid over the Mortal Realm, they did not find any trace left by supernatural powers or supernatural objects.

“This is not right…” After they finished a rough check of the last building, Dog finally voiced his doubt. “That Veil that covers the fire must be the work of some supernatural power. But we searched the whole factory zone and never found the ‘source’ of the Veil… that makes no sense.”

“Does there have to be a source?” Shirley asked, curious.

Duncan was just as curious, but he did not show it. He kept his face tense and waited quietly for Dog to explain.

Anyone else would probably never guess it, but of the three “people” on site, the only Occult Specialist was actually the dog…

Dog himself did not think too much about it. As a Abyssal demon, a lot of knowledge about the supernatural was basically common sense to him. He explained without hesitation: “The force that hides the traces of the fire is clearly a continuous power. It needs a source to keep it going until now. Also, after Mr. Duncan’s fire faded, the Veil closed up again. That means there is something behind it supporting this Veil. It might be a powerful Anomaly object, or a powerful supernatural being. Either way, whatever it is, it must exist somewhere in the city-state…”

As he spoke, the Abyssal Hound raised his skull and swept his hollow eye sockets across the distant streets and the further city.

“We did not find the source of the Veil inside the factory. That means the thing that keeps the Veil standing is projecting its power here from far away. Or… the scale of the Veil is far beyond what we imagine, and we only lifted a tiny corner of it. If it is the second case…”

Dog suddenly lowered his voice, sounding a little nervous: “If it is the second case, then this will be very hard to handle. An ordinary Anomaly could never cover such a large area. It would have to be a Vision. An unknown Vision…”

“The shard of the Sun can not be counted as an ordinary ‘Anomaly object’. After all, according to those cultists, that shard is the corpse of the Sun god,” Shirley suddenly said. “Maybe this is the shard’s way of hiding itself.”

“A higher Anomaly that can think, then?” Dog murmured. “To avoid being controlled, it actively created the Veil, erased every trace of its own existence, and hid somewhere behind the Veil? That is indeed possible. If it is the corpse of a deity, it might already be able to think even before it wakes.”

Shirley pinched her chin and thought seriously. Then something seemed to occur to her. She looked at Dog in surprise: “So you are actually this knowledgeable, Dog? And you cannot even read…”

“I am a Abyssal demon! A shadow shaped from the flesh of the Abyssal Lord! This knowledge was carved into my memory from birth, alright?” Dog rattled his chains impatiently. “And speaking of not being able to read… you have the nerve to talk about me?!”

Duncan watched Shirley and her Abyssal Hound with interest. This strange pair clearly had many secrets, and that made him even more curious. But before he could ask anything, Shirley suddenly seemed to remember something. She looked up at the sky with some panic. Seeing the Sun

slowly climbing toward the highest point, she cried out: “Ah! It is already noon!”

Duncan raised his brows: “You have other plans?”

“I…” Shirley answered nervously. “I have to be home before noon!”

Duncan looked quietly at the girl. “Did you not say your parents are gone? Who will lecture you if you go back late?”

“It is not a lecture… I have an appointment with someone!” Shirley waved her hands quickly. Maybe because of what they had gone through together in the factory, she dared to act a little bolder in front of Duncan. “I… maybe we can continue next time?”

Duncan glanced at the Abyssal Hound beside her. Dog instantly shrank his neck. “It is up to you. If you want to keep exploring, I and Shirley…”

“No need,” Duncan shook his head. “Continuing to search here will not give us much more. We will talk again after we find new clues. Since you two have other matters, go.”

Shirley’s face lit up at once. She clearly had not expected the big boss to let her leave so easily. But she did not dare run off without another word. She carefully confirmed: “Then… Dog and I will go first, alright? In the future, if you want to find us…”

Duncan only smiled and looked at her kindly. “If we are fated, we will meet again.”

He smiled gently at Shirley and Dog. In his eyes, on the black chain that bound the Abyssal Hound, a tiny green spark was quietly smoldering.

After his unexpected link with Vanna last time, he had gained a deeper understanding of the fire of his spirit form. This was the result, a small test.

This mark was something he had released on purpose. It was stronger than the little flame he had left on Vanna, yet it was gentle and harmless.

Shirley suddenly felt a chill run over her skin. Duncan’s smile was so warm, yet she wanted to shiver.

In the end, she still held her expression steady and said goodbye as politely as she could, then hurried away with Dog.

Chapter 116: Everything Was Normal

Shirley quickly left with Dog, while Duncan withdrew his gaze from the distant intersection and let it fall again on the factory ruins.

After the fire of the spirit form faded, the invisible Veil closed again, and the factory returned to its former “normal” appearance—the traces of the blaze were wiped clean, and the omnipresent ash sank into nothingness.

Duncan’s line of sight slowly lifted, moving above the factory, up into the sky.

He imagined a thin, gauzy curtain quietly draped over everything, hiding the truth beneath the Mortal Realm. The Sixth District did not have many residents left, but there were still a few thousand people. And right under the eyes of those thousands, the invisible Veil had covered the truth for eleven years.

The residents here had even forgotten that fire from their memories. They only thought it was a “chemical corruption” leaked from the factory that left the district in ruins.

Thinking of this, Duncan suddenly frowned.

The truth inside the factory was a great fire, and Dog had also confirmed that there was no chemical corruption residue around the factory. Since there was no so-called “corruption” at all… then what had kept the entire Sixth District from seeing a single newborn for eleven years?!

If the break in newborns was not caused by chemical corruption… was it some power from the supernatural field that stopped new lives from appearing in the Sixth District?

Duncan looked at the sky, deep in thought.

It seemed… that invisible Veil was even larger in scope than he had imagined.

…

“Did we get out… did we really get out?”

In a shabby alley a ways away from the Sixth District, Shirley poked her head out of the shadows. She carefully checked the street nearby for patrolling constables, then lowered her voice and spoke toward the corner of the wall beside her.

At the corner of the wall, a clump of inky shadows coiled there, as if formless darkness had turned thick and sticky. Dog hid inside that shadow and spoke in a low, muffled voice: “We didn’t get out. Some big shot let us go.”

“Same damn thing.” Shirley waved a hand and plopped right down on the ground, not caring at all how she looked. “Hell, I was scared to death… I didn’t even dare breathe too loud, couldn’t swear the whole time, had to pretend to be all obedient… Dog, you have no idea…”

“I know. I can see more things than you. Did you forget?” The voice in the shadows spoke in a faint tone. “How did it feel? Walking next to a smiling Subspace shadow, was that more tiring than dealing with a bunch of fierce constables and Guardians?”

“…Stop talking, I’m getting chills.” Shirley rolled her eyes. “It’s all your fault for scaring me like that last time. If I didn’t know anything, I wouldn’t have been scared today… Tell me, why do big shots like that have to

pretend to be ‘ordinary people’? He even squeezed onto the public bus like an ordinary person, even bought a ticket! Who would think they’d run into him that way?!”

Dog went quiet for two seconds. “…Maybe it’s just a hobby. Maybe he’s watching you. That’s what I’m most afraid of… We’ve already dealt with a being like that. I’m afraid our fate is already tangled up.”

Shirley shivered a little and asked carefully: “You mean… we’ll really run into him again? Give me a break…”

“Did you forget what he said when you parted?” Dog sighed. “He will find us.”

Shirley did not speak for a moment. She just lowered her head in silence. After a while, Dog suddenly said: “What is it? Scared now? Regretting it? It might be a bit late for that… I warned you before. Once you step into the supernatural field, you have to be ready to deal with all kinds of higher-order powers. Most of those things are beyond human imagination—if you had listened to me a few months ago and not started digging into those old events, you could still be living your peaceful life…”

“Like hell I regret it!” Shirley cut him off fiercely, still keeping her head down. “I never regretted it from the start, and I never will! Stop saying that depressing crap to me!”

“Alright, alright, I won’t say it—have you rested enough? We should get moving. Didn’t that ‘new friend’ of yours make an appointment with you?”

“I… I’ll wait two more minutes.” Shirley scratched her hair, her voice a little muffled. “My legs are a bit weak. Let me rest a bit…”

Dog said nothing more, only let out a hoarse purring sound. The writhing shadows hiding him slowly shrank and melted into Shirley’s own shadow.

…

At lunchtime, Vanna stuffed a piece of bread spread with jam into her mouth. She gulped it down in big bites while reading the briefing papers at her hand. She felt a bit choked, so she grabbed the glass next to her and took several big gulps.

Her uncle Dante's voice came from across the table, full of helplessness: "Vanna, eat a little more elegantly—and stop drinking wine like it's water."

"Heretics don't wait. The sooner I shorten my meal, the sooner I can send those heretics to meet their lord." Vanna looked up at her uncle as she struggled to swallow the food in her mouth. "And it's not like we're at some banquet outside…"

"Even family meals need proper manners—behaving like this, you'll never get married." Dante looked, head aching, at his niece, who had reached marriageable age and had not brought home even one boyfriend. "Sigh, actually, I should say you already can't get married…"

Vanna finally slowed down. The young Inquisitor looked a little embarrassed. "I… an Inquisitor's duties are rather…"

"The Deep Sea Church doesn't forbid priests to marry. Inquisitors also have normal families. I've read the Storm Canon too." Dante shook his head. "Seriously, there really isn't anyone suitable?"

Vanna lowered her head and poked the bread on her plate with her table knife. "The main problem is that none of them can fight."

"…You really should ask if that vow can be taken back." Dante sighed, looking deeply worried. "You shouldn't have made that oath so casually when you took your rites back then, especially the first line, insisting that only someone strong could walk beside you. Bishop Valentine should have stopped you…"

Vanna lowered her head even more. Though tall and strong, she now looked completely embarrassed. Being scolded by her uncle, she was just like when she was a child, even her voice sounded muffled: “You can’t just take back a vow. It’s a sacred promise made before the Goddess. And… I wouldn’t call it casual. Almost every female Guardian has that line in her vow. It’s a symbol of the courage the storm gave us, and it is to prove to the Goddess that…”

Dante silently looked at his niece, who was a head and a half taller than he was. “Did you ever think that one day you might train yourself to be unbeatable?”

“…That was for the second and third lines of the vow…” Vanna muttered.

“…Sigh.”

This had become a topic the uncle and niece brought up every few days in the past year or two, and every time it ended in awkwardness. This time was no exception.

But Vanna quickly adjusted her mood. She finished the battle on her plate at an amazing speed, then gathered the papers at her side and got up to leave: “I’m done eating, Uncle, you… huh?”

Vanna suddenly stopped. She stared in surprise at Dante Wayne’s face and pointed at his ruby prosthetic eye. “Uncle, the wound around your eye is bleeding… Are you alright?”

“Huh?” Dante froze for a moment. He quickly raised a hand to touch it. Seeing the blood on his fingers, he hurriedly stood up to get a mirror and checked his artificial eye. He saw, to his shock, that the edge of that ruby eye was slowly seeping blood. The blood ran along the wrinkled scars around the wound. There was not much of it, but it looked frightening.

“Don’t move yet.” Vanna rushed over and pressed her hand near Dante’s eye while quietly reciting lines from the Storm Canon: “May the sea wind moisten the flesh and make this body whole again.”

Under the sacred prayer, Dante felt a slight itch around his wound, and the little bit of bleeding soon stopped. He sounded a bit helpless: “No need to make such a fuss. This isn’t the first time over these years. It’s cold stone and metal after all. A little ‘small conflict’ with living flesh now and then is normal.”

But the expression on Vanna’s face did not relax at all. She kept staring at Dante’s ruby eye. After a long time, she asked: “Do you feel anything else? Any burning pain? Or do you see any phantoms through this ruby gem eye?”

Dante blinked. He looked at Vanna. The blessed ruby gem eye clearly reflected everything it saw—

Flames burned fiercely behind Vanna. Ash and char marks covered the dining room. Shapeless charcoal and melted heaps hung down from the ceiling like an inverted omen.

The ruby gem eye grew slightly hot, then slowly cooled again.

Dante smiled. “Of course not. Everything was normal.”

—

Chapter 117: The City Museum

Getting off the carriage and stepping onto the stone square in front of the City Museum, Heidi could not help taking a deep breath. The cool, slightly salty sea wind blew past, as if it also blew away the fatigue and anxiety she had built up after working for so long without a break, bringing her a trace of ease.

This young psychiatrist had not taken a day off for almost a month. Lately she had been dealing with raving, deranged cultists almost every day. She even felt that the madness in those cultists' heads was slowly infecting her own mind, leaving her fighting insomnia and bad dreams every night.

Thankfully, today she finally did not have to think about those mad cultists and their twisted, diseased minds.

Another gust of sea wind blew in from the end of the street, stirring the hem of Heidi's dress. She raised a hand to press down her long skirt and the wide-brimmed hat on her head, then looked up at the large white building ahead, with its sleek dome and pretty side wings.

This maritime City Museum in the Crossroad District was one of the largest museums in the city-state of Pland—and also one of the most legendary.

Heidi walked toward the City Museum. Not far away, a guide was explaining the museum's background to a group of visitors. The guide's rather carrying voice drifted into Heidi's ears:

"…This large building, built in 1802, was originally the property of the Parr Brothers Oceanic Trade Company. At its height, as Pland's largest storage

center, it handled astonishing amounts of wealth and was seen as a symbol of the city-state's peak of commercial prosperity. But a great upheaval in 1822 completely changed the fate of this building…"

Someone asked at just the right moment: "What happened back then?"

"They say—just a rumor, mind you—that one of the Parr Brothers' ocean-going cargo ships ran into a strange dense fog on its way back to port. In that fog, the unlucky ship saw a ghost ship wreathed in flames and passed right by it…

"That cargo ship somehow escaped the fog and even returned safely to the Harbor. But the mad shadows stayed in the hearts of every crew member on board and quickly spread through the Parr Brothers' entire fleet. In the months that followed, every ship under their name began to suffer terrible disasters. Crew members kept mutinying and disappearing. Some even performed bloody sacrifices to please some unknown deity…

"…Ships on long voyages hit storms on seas that should have been calm, or struck icebergs in warm waters. Mutinous sailors blew up explosives on board, sabotaged boilers, even hunted down their own crewmates… Disasters like that kept happening, and in the end they completely ruined the Parr Brothers' business, forcing their ocean trade company to file for bankruptcy restructuring at the end of the same year…

"After that, the Parr Brothers divided up what remained of the company's assets and donated part of it to the city-state's authority, including this building in front of us… It then went through several renovations and changes of function. Until in 1855, it was finally converted into a maritime City Museum, and has remained so to this day.

"They say that even today, the shadows from nearly a century ago still wander this maritime City Museum… The shadows of the Parr Brothers sometimes return to the museum and stop for a while in their old office. Or

staff in the old ocean trade uniforms appear in the exhibition halls and ask confusedly for directions to the office area…

“Of course, of course! These are only rumors. The inside of the City Museum has already been inspected and blessed by Church priests, and a squad of Guardians is stationed here to make sure no supernatural disasters break out. Everyone can visit with peace of mind—but if any of you really are interested in those spooky stories, you can try the ‘Adventure Chamber’ in the side wing of the museum. Before going into the chamber, though, you have to go to the Cathedral on the square for a temporary baptism and a will test…”

The voices of the guide and the tourists slowly faded. Heidi moved past the crowd toward the front, but suddenly her steps felt a bit heavy.

An ocean trade warehouse from a century ago. Distant sea fog that brought disaster. A fleet under a curse. Shadows wandering in the City Museum…

Heidi had been dealing with cultists every day lately and had heard plenty of “rumors” through various official channels. She suddenly felt that choosing the City Museum as a sightseeing spot for her day off might not have been a good idea… With this time, she might as well go wander around the Lower City instead, or let herself be talked into it by her father and go visit that strange antique shop.

But after less than two seconds of hesitation, the young psychiatrist suddenly made up her mind. She strode toward the main entrance of the City Museum.

Telling just the right amount of spooky stories when introducing a spot was a common trick for guides. More than half the horror tales in this world involved sea fog, ghost ships, and mutinous sailors. If the City Museum had its ghost stories, the antique shop might have things even scarier than ghosts

—could a psychiatrist who dealt with lunatics all day really be afraid of that?

No one could stop her from enjoying this hard-won day off! Not even an Eldritch God from Subspace!

With her resolve firm and her steps light as the wind, Miss Psychiatrist strode through the ticket gate like a warrior marching off to battle, passed through the doors of the City Museum, and stepped into this ancient building that had stood for nearly a century.

There were fewer visitors inside the City Museum than she had expected. Perhaps because it was not a public holiday, the first-floor hall even felt a little empty.

A few members of the museum’s mental guidance staff were helping confused visitors find the route to the main exhibits. At the far end of the first-floor hall, a towering wall held the huge skeleton of a whale and fine models of all kinds of sea vessels. A guide dressed as a captain was explaining the early age of sailing warships to several children.

Two girls who looked only sixteen or seventeen, probably still in school, were walking together toward the door that led to the main exhibition area. They chatted and laughed along the way, looking very close.

The lighting in the hall was bright, and the atmosphere was pleasant.

Heidi let out a small breath of relief and followed behind the two young girls, walking toward the hall of the main exhibits, ready to enjoy this quiet time.

Then she caught a faint strange smell.

It smelled… as if something was burning…

…

Near the Crossroad District, Duncan stepped off a steam bus. He bought a light magazine at a nearby newsstand, planning to use it to pass some time.

His investigation around the factory ruins had not made much progress. After Shirley and Dog left, he wandered around the Sixth District for a long time and asked the locals about various things. But clearly, citizens who were ordinary people could not possibly glimpse the truth behind the Veil. The residents of the Sixth District only remembered the little bit of information the authorities had released. Everyone believed the district's decline was caused by chemical corruption left behind by the factory and by the city-state authority's neglect. It was no different from what that old man sunning himself had told him.

The truth was covered by the Veil. Records in the Mortal Realm had been altered, and what the city-state authority released was only the information after it had been edited. But Duncan could not decide, based on this alone, that the Veil had been created by Pland's City Hall or the Church—for in a world where supernatural phenomena existed, a powerful Anomaly or Vision could just as easily blind everyone.

In the face of powerful Anomalies and Visions, even the so-called "Mortal Realm" was a canvas that could be smeared over and rewritten.

Now it seemed that the source of that "Veil" was not in the factory at all, and might not even be in the Sixth District. If this so-called "source" was the fragment of the Sun, then it should be hidden somewhere even deeper.

The investigation could not continue before he had more leads.

Duncan sat down on a bench by the street. He read the light magazine absentmindedly while thinking about what to do next.

Those Suntists were searching for the fragment of the Sun, throwing the city-state into turmoil. Nina's memories and dreams vaguely pointed toward

that fragment. She was very likely connected to it in some way. And through the Sun mask, he had glimpsed the Sun's true form. That unspeakable thing, shaped like an Eldritch God, had already seen him and had called to him for help…

Before he knew it, he seemed to have fallen into a tangled skein of threads.

The city-state of Pland was his first landing point in the civilized world. He had thought it was a peaceful, prosperous, and tranquil place, but he had not expected this "first stop" to be so far from peaceful.

Duncan sighed and shook his head slightly. Just then, from the corner of his eye, he suddenly saw a strange column of smoke rising above a nearby block.

Within the smoke, firelight faintly leaped.

Duncan froze for a moment and rose from the bench. He noticed that many other people on the street had seen the smoke and flames as well. Many pedestrians stopped in their tracks. Then he saw someone run across the street in a panic and heard a shout:

"It's on fire! the City Museum is on fire!!"

Chapter 118: The Fire Scene

Thick smoke rose into the air, with faint firelight flickering inside it. People were running along the street, shouting in panic, and the moment Duncan heard their cries, his eyes widened a little.

The Ocean City Museum… the one near Crossroad District… Nina!

This afternoon, Nina had gone with her classmates to visit the Ocean City Museum near Crossroad District. That was exactly the direction where the smoke was rising!

Duncan started forward at once, wanting to run straight toward the museum. But he quickly realized that getting there from this part of the city would not be easy. Even if the smoke looked close to the naked eye, the winding streets would waste a lot of time. Taking a cab was not realistic either—not only was traffic here not that convenient, but even if he did manage to flag down a car, no driver would want to head straight into a burning building.

His mind raced. He was anxious, but he did not lose his calm. After he quickly sorted through the situation, a bold idea appeared in his heart.

“AI!” he ordered silently, suddenly speeding up as he slipped into the shadows of a nearby alley.

A flash of green spirit flame swept past. AI, who had been patrolling nearby, appeared out of thin air, flapped her wings, and landed on Duncan’s shoulder.

Duncan turned his head to look at the pigeon and had already sorted out his plan in his mind.

He knew this bird could carry physical objects across space and keep the “cargo” perfectly intact during the trip. He also knew her carrying capacity was quite large—so far, none of their tests had reached her limit.

So… could she “carry” him to the Ocean City Museum?

The bold thought quickly grew firm, and Duncan could not help a small sigh in his heart. He had never tried having AI carry a living person through space. It was a very dangerous experiment. And lately he had not managed to find any cultist willing to sacrifice themselves for the sake of research. Originally he had planned to wait for AI to bring back some “prey” before arranging human trials. He had not expected something like this to happen so soon… but maybe that was just as well.

Since he could not find a test subject, he would use his own body and soul, which were not afraid of death, as the first experimental target. No matter what, AI could at least keep the “cargo” intact during transport. That meant this body should arrive whole in the streets near the Ocean City Museum. And if this body really died again in the teleportation because of some mysterious power… he would just project himself from the Vanished again and possess it. He would treat it as a second upload.

“I want you to ‘deliver a shipment’,” Duncan said as he patted AI’s wing. “Deliver it to the Ocean City Museum in Crossroad District—the big white building you flew past this morning.”

AI tilted her head. As clever as a human, she had already guessed Duncan’s intention the moment she saw the dark smoke on the horizon: “A trip that starts the moment we say go?”

“Just tell me if you can do it.”

“Then let’s…”

“Do it.”

Without another word, the pigeon beat her wings hard. A burst of green spirit flame exploded out of nowhere, turning her into a skeletal dove made of spirit flame. She rose into the air and circled quickly around Duncan.

In the next second, the ghostly green blaze flashed and vanished. Duncan’s avatar turned into a stream of light and disappeared into the whirlpool of fire.

One second later, a snow?white pigeon shot up from the shadows deep in the alley and soared toward the next street, heading straight for the thick black column of smoke that was growing more and more intense.

Near the Ocean City Museum in Crossroad District, fire squad members who had rushed over from the fire station were already trying to fight this sudden blaze. Thanks to the District’s good basic infrastructure and the museum’s special status as a public building, there were not only resident fire units nearby but also plenty of emergency pumps and evacuation exits.

By the time the fire squad members started trying to put out the flames, some of the people trapped inside the museum had already escaped through the emergency exits on either side of the main building. They gathered anxiously at the edge of the plaza.

People were talking in terror about the flames that had suddenly burst out in the corridors and halls. They spoke of strange, howling explosions from the depths of the museum and twisted, impossible shapes in the fire. Some people were clearly having hallucinations under the pressure and kept describing scenes that were far too terrifying. That only made the panic spread faster.

But the professionals were already at work. The priests from the Cathedral on the plaza and the resident Guardians were very experienced at handling early signs of corruption caused by mass mental stress. Two priests had already walked into the crowd. They lit censers beside the people who were most agitated, trying to calm their emotions. Several Guardians began to split the crowd apart, taking away those who showed potential signs of corruption, preparing to give them later mental comfort and a Will Test.

In the shadows of a building a few dozen meters from the museum plaza, a cluster of green light and flame suddenly rose up.

The ghostly green flame swirled and gathered, like a door opening in midair. Duncan stepped out from it. Threads of fire still clung to his clothes, drifting away on the wind as he walked out of the shadows. AI flapped her wings and settled neatly back onto his shoulder.

Duncan glanced back at AI and quietly noted down this new experience and the feeling of performing a “live teleportation.”

Just as he had expected, AI had reached the Ocean City Museum by “flying,” not by instantly arriving as she did when Teleporting between the antique shop and the Vanished.

That meant AI’s teleportation had to be built on anchors. When she teleported between the antique shop and the Vanished, the anchors were the antique shopkeeper and the “Captain.” But when she carried one of those anchors with her, she could only fly honestly through the space of the Mortal Realm to get from place to place.

As for what it felt like to be “carried” in flight by AI… it was strange.

He had not lost consciousness during the process, but he could not clearly see his surroundings either. Through the link of the spirit flame, he could vaguely share AI’s senses. He could faintly see views from high above and

feel the air rushing past his body. But all these shared senses seemed to be separated by a layer of the Veil. They were not as clear or direct as his own body’s senses.

Maybe it was because AI’s body was too different from a human’s. Or maybe it was because AI had her own will and could not be completely taken over.

But those were small problems, and Duncan did not care about them right now. Unlocking AI’s “new function” in a moment of crisis was already a huge gain. He could study the details later. For now, the most important thing was to find out how Nina was.

Flying was not as fast as true teleportation. It had taken a few minutes to get here from the nearby district. But compared to running or taking normal transport, this speed was already amazing. He had not lost much time on the way.

Duncan could already see the burning building. The white main structure of the Ocean City Museum had three floors. The fire on the first and second floors was the fiercest. Thick smoke poured from several windows on the second floor, and flames burst and rolled out of some of them. A column of smoke also rose from the rooftop, with faint tongues of fire licking out from it.

The way the flames were spread made it look as if a giant pillar of fire had exploded on the first floor and punched straight through the upper floors and the roof.

The fire squad members had opened several hydrants at the edge of the plaza. Huge jets of high?pressure water blasted toward the museum’s main building, trying to cool the outer walls and prevent this century?old structure from collapsing in an even more deadly way. Some survivors had

gathered at the edge of the plaza, accepting comfort from the priests or answering questions from officials.

Duncan walked straight toward these survivors, looking carefully to see if Nina was among them.

Halfway there, he heard some of the survivors trembling as they described what they had seen.

“…The fire just appeared in the air! It really came out of nowhere! It was like it had been burning for a long, long time but no one could see it, and then it suddenly showed itself!”

“There was a howling sound, a sharp howl, like a demon laughing!”

“…A man whose whole body was burned black crawled out of a room—Goddess above! He was wearing clothes from decades ago… He crawled out of the room, but that room wasn’t on fire before! The fire only started after he came out!”

The survivors at the edge of the plaza were deeply terrified. Many of them were talking over each other as they described what they had seen. Duncan walked up beside them and saw a priest of the Deep Sea Church in a long robe, with a short black beard, frowning deeply.

“The panic rate is too high. A third of them are mentally unstable,” the Deep Sea priest said quickly to the Guardian warrior beside him. “They show signs of being corrupted by supernatural power… There may be something unclean inside the museum. When will support from the main Cathedral arrive?”

“At least half an hour.”

“…That’s not good. We don’t have that long. If there really is something unclean, at this scale it will probably go into a runaway state in ten, maybe fifteen minutes…” The black?robed priest glanced at the burning museum,

then suddenly turned to an attendant at his side. “Have the constables take over things here.”

Then he grabbed the front of his priest robe and tore it off in one motion, revealing a black shirt and trousers underneath. He raised the Storm Canon in his hand and shouted a short, loud benediction:

“Please, bear witness! We go forward without fear!”

The other Guardians shouted together: “Please, bear witness!”

Right after the benediction, a faint mist rose around the Storm believers, wrapping their bodies like protective waves. In the next second, they charged toward the burning building.

(A young man from Earth named Colin died in a car accident, crossed into a chaotic era where supplies were scarce, and obtained a “Bronze Immortal Gate”…)

Chapter 119: A Pair of Friends

From the moment the Deep Sea priest judged that there might be an supernatural Runaway inside the museum to the moment he finished his self?blessing and led the charge into the fire, only about ten seconds passed.

Duncan watched the group rush toward the flames. The fire squad on the plaza immediately moved to support them, working with practiced skill. They used the hoses to cover the entrance, cooling it down and clearing a path. Another team quickly formed up. On top of their standard protective gear, they hung the insignia of the Deep Sea Church and something like amulets. They also rushed into the Ocean City Museum.

The constables who stayed at the edge of the plaza took over calming and guiding the rest of the citizens. They began contacting the nearby Cathedral to receive the fire survivors who had already been marked as possibly corrupted.

They were well trained and worked together tightly. It was not just something they had drilled countless times. It felt like something they had done in real disasters countless times.

This was the face of a city?state that had survived in a strange world full of supernatural phenomena and grown prosperous. They could quickly pick out the shadow of the supernatural in any disaster. They could suppress corruption before it exploded beyond what Mortals could bear. Both supernatural and ordinary people received full education and training in these matters, until their basic responses became muscle memory. Only then could the whole group keep living on.

Duncan saw all of this, but he did not have much time to think about it. He checked every soot?covered survivor at the edge of the plaza, but Nina was nowhere to be seen.

He suddenly looked up at the museum.

From inside the burning Ocean City Museum, a somewhat familiar aura was drifting out.

He started to walk toward the museum, but after only two steps, a constable blocked his way: “Mister, it’s dangerous ahead. Please leave it to the professionals.”

Duncan glanced at the constable, nodded, and turned away.

Arguing with the officials here would only waste time and get in the way of the professionals’ work. Duncan was a practical man, so he simply gave up on the main entrance of the museum. He circled quickly to the other side of the plaza and hid himself in the shadows of a building.

The next second, a white dove flew straight across the plaza and dove right through a side window of the museum that was spitting flames.

Some people saw this and only thought it was a poor pigeon, scared and half?stunned by the smoke and fire. After a few sighs, they stopped paying attention.

Inside the Ocean City Museum, Duncan stepped out of a vortex of ghostly green flame.

Smoke, firelight, and heat rushed toward him at once.

Duncan did not fear these things, but he could feel this mortal body’s functions straining under the conditions inside the burning building. If he just walked forward like this, his soul might be fine, but this body would definitely not survive.

But he was not acting blindly. Before he rushed in, he already knew what he had to do.

The place was full of fire—and fire was very obedient.

Duncan held his breath. A faint trail of ghostly green flame flowed under his feet, then vanished in an instant. With that brief contact, he had already formed an invisible link with the flames around him. Just like in the underground sun cultists' gathering place beneath the abandoned factory, he felt the surrounding fire submit to him.

Even the burning air itself began to change. It no longer affected this body's breathing.

Duncan took a gentle breath and walked toward a door that was sealed by raging flames.

"Back."

The fire pulled back at his word. It retreated and slowly died out behind him, revealing a corridor full of smoke and scattered embers.

Duncan glanced over his shoulder, then looked at the signs on the nearby walls. He judged that he had "landed" in an office on the edge of the main exhibition area. The corridor in front of him was a service passage used by the museum staff. At the end of it lay the main exhibition halls. On one side were stairs and a shaft lift leading to other floors.

He stepped into the corridor and moved forward, searching ahead while he focused his mind, trying to sense where Nina was inside the museum. Honestly, he had no idea if he could pull it off.

It was his first time trying something like this. His senses might now be far beyond a normal person's, and Goathead had said "a captain's intuition is the surest compass," but for him, trying to sense someone's aura from far

away like this was still an unfamiliar, high?level trick—something he had only seen in stories.

He was only trying it now because, back on the plaza, he had felt a faint trace of a familiar aura from inside the museum for a moment. That gave him the idea to try.

Duncan walked down the corridor. The flames along the way retreated and went out one by one. He still could not sense where Nina was, but suddenly, he felt something else.

“Hm?”

He muttered in confusion and turned toward the direction his senses pointed. Not far ahead, on the lower level beneath a staircase, a “mark” was growing clearer and clearer in his perception, pulsing faintly.

The mark’s owner seemed to be very much alive and kicking.

Duncan hesitated for only a moment, then broke into a run, heading straight toward the source of the feeling. He ran through the flames that kept backing away and dying out. He went down a staircase that was already starting to crack and loosen, while pushing his control over the fire as far as his body could safely handle, trying to suppress the blaze in the whole building.

At the same time, the mark in his mind grew sharper. In the end, he even began to faintly hear the “voice” coming from it—

“…My hand? Hey, these are just small burns. Give me two or three days and they’ll be fine…

“Yeah, I’ve always been pretty strong…

“Don’t worry, I blocked up the crack under the door. The smoke won’t get in for now… You’re really smart, you even knew there was a water room

here… Uh, you checked the route map before? The teacher talked about it in class? Safety education… um… I might not have listened very well, hahaha…

“You said you saw a dog just now? You must’ve seen wrong. How could there be a dog in a place like this, hahaha…

“…What do we do about this one who fainted? You don’t know either? All right… at least she’s still alive… It’s fine, we’re definitely going to be rescued…”

He was not mistaken. That was Shirley’s voice.

Duncan recognized the mark. It was the little bit of fire he had placed on Shirley not long ago, and her voice was now reaching his mind through that mark.

Back on the plaza, that instant when he had felt a trace of familiarity from the museum seemed to have come from this mark as well. He had not tried to contact it on purpose, but because he was too close, he had sensed its presence anyway.

This mark was the first one Duncan had ever actively released, so there were still many things about it he did not understand. But now it seemed that the connection between spirit flames was even more useful than he had imagined.

As that thought passed through his mind, another question rose up:

Shirley was talking to someone, and from the sound of it, that person was her friend… Who was with her?

…

The closed water room had become a temporary shelter. The narrow, cramped space kept out the disaster drawing closer outside. Water still ran

in the sink not far away. The electric light had gone out, and the flickering firelight coming through the window was the only source of light. Nina curled up carefully beside the sink, and she could almost count her own heartbeats.

They were beating abnormally fast.

Her new friend, the girl named Shirley, was checking the seals on the doors and windows. Shirley's hands had been burned by the flames, but she acted as if nothing were wrong and kept working busily. On the floor not far away lay another lady. Nina had never met this woman before. On the way here, in the chaos, she had seen a loose brick knock the lady out. She and Shirley had dragged her into this room together.

From the woman's clothes and style, it was clear she was not a poor person from the Lower City like Nina, but a proper young miss from the Upper City. Unfortunately, in the face of disaster, proper ladies and the poor of the Lower City did not seem very different.

The sound of water from the sink suddenly grew weaker, then stopped.

"…The main pump just shut down," Nina said. She had been listening to the sounds in the room the whole time. "The fire is very big."

Her "new friend," who was a whole head shorter than her, walked over and squatted down in front of her. In the dark, their eyes were on the same level.

"Are you really scared?" Shirley asked quietly.

"I'm very scared of fire…" Nina hugged her legs tightly. Even her voice was shaking a little. "Really, really scared of fire."

"…Actually, I'm pretty scared too," Shirley said after a two?second silence. "All right, I'm the most scared—I'm more afraid of fire than anything…"

“You can’t tell at all,” Nina said, shaking her head. “You were charging around like crazy just now.”

“I was charging around because I was scared,” Shirley said, flopping down to sit beside her. “I’m so scared that if I ever stop, I’ll never have the courage to rush in again… But now it’s fine. The two of us are damn well stuck in here, and there’s nowhere left to run, so we can only sit here like two idiots and wait.”

In the dark, Nina reached out and bumped Shirley’s arm. She suddenly noticed that Shirley was trembling too.

So Shirley really was very scared as well.

“You swear,” Nina said softly. “I thought… you were a very well? mannered, good student.”

“At a time like this, there’s no point in pretending. I’ve always been like this,” Shirley said, a bright smile on her smoke?blackened face. “And… forget it.”

She seemed about to say something more to Nina, but in the end she swallowed it back. She turned her head to glance at the door and said: “Come on, use that smart brain of yours. How long do you think we can stay alive in here?”

Nina raised her head and looked around: “I… don’t know either. But as long as we keep the smoke out, we’re safe for now. This room is very sturdy, and it’s at the bend of the stairs. It shouldn’t collapse for a while.”

Shirley gave a careless “oh,” then hesitated for a moment before speaking again, slowly: “So… I mean, if I—if I had a way to get us out of here, but it might be pretty scary, would you… want to try it?”

“A way?” Nina looked at her in confusion. “What way?”

“Well…” Shirley stood up, then suddenly sat back down again. “Ah, forget it. Let’s wait a bit longer. It’s not time yet. Not yet…”

Nina: “…?”

Chapter 120: Rescue

Time suddenly seemed to slow to a crawl. In the darkness and the scorching heat that crept closer and closer, Nina felt her mind start running out of control.

She seemed to remember her childhood. She remembered running up and down the antique shop with her uncle, ‘helping out’ and only making a mess of everything. She remembered her uncle explaining the stories behind those ‘antiques’, which all turned out to be made up. She remembered her first day at school, the first time she saw a steam engine in a textbook, the first praise she got from a teacher, the first friend she made… and the first friend she lost.

Her head felt like a tangled ball of yarn, and her thoughts grew more and more confused.

Smoke had already started seeping into the room bit by bit. It made it hard to breathe and also harder to think.

In the end, all those noisy, scattered memories turned into the image of being swallowed by flames.

A great fire… a fire that existed only in her memories seemed to blaze up again before her eyes.

Nina stared in a daze at the floor not far away, her gaze unfocused, as if that patch of ground would suddenly burst into flames in the next second. Just then, she felt a cold hand press against her forehead.

Shirley looked at her friend with some worry and asked: “Are you alright? Your eyes suddenly went blank… and you kept mumbling something under your breath.”

Nina hurriedly shook her head, grabbed Shirley’s arm, and said: “I… I’m fine. Thanks… I just suddenly thought about my family.”

Shirley froze for a moment when she heard the word “family”, then asked, as if casually: “Who do you have at home?”

Nina thought for a moment, slowly lowered her head onto her knees, and said: “Only an uncle… my parents have been gone for many years. I grew up with my uncle. I promised him I would come home early today…”

Shirley seemed a bit uneasy with this topic and did not really know how to comfort her friend, so she forced herself to keep talking: “You… you must be very close with your uncle, right? What does he do?”

Nina spoke slowly: “He’s just an ordinary person. Our family runs an antique shop in the Lower City. He manages it by himself…” When she noticed the surprise on Shirley’s face, she quickly waved her hands. “Not the kind of very impressive antique shop you’re thinking of. There aren’t any real antiques.”

Shirley hurried to flatter her: “That still sounds amazing! A shopkeeper! Owning your own store, even in the Lower City… your family must be doing pretty well, right?”

Nina kept waving her hands: “Actually it’s very average. My uncle’s health wasn’t very good a few years ago, and business at the shop isn’t great. We haven’t saved much money… But I think my uncle is really amazing. He can even chat with Mr. Morris M for a very long time! He knows a lot of things. Even Mr. Morris M says he’s a very learned person…”

After listening to Nina’s story, Shirley pretended to nod very seriously and said: “Then once we get out of here, I definitely have to meet your uncle…”

Nina smiled and was just about to say something when a loud bang suddenly came from the door. The next second, the flimsy washroom door was kicked open from the outside and crashed to the floor!

The moment she saw this, Nina’s first reaction was that the blaze in the hallway outside would flare up because the door was broken and sweep inside. That was what she had learned at school. But in the next second, she only saw a familiar figure step through the doorway—the burst of fire she expected did not appear.

Shirley was also startled by the crash of the broken door. She turned her head in shock, and the moment she saw the figure in the doorway, her whole body went stiff.

She saw that Subspace Shadow’s avatar form standing quietly in the doorway. In the corner of her eye, the last tongues of flame were crawling at that figure’s feet and fading away. She got up in a daze, wanting to back away with a trace of fear. For a split second she even considered whether she should push this new “friend” Nina toward the door, but before she could do anything, Nina had already stood up behind her.

Nina looked at the figure in the doorway in surprise and joy and called out: “Uncle Duncan?!” In that instant, it was as if all her fear and pressure vanished with his appearance.

Duncan also looked at the young lady with some surprise and said: “Nina?” He had actually followed the mark he had left on Shirley to find this place. He had planned to find Shirley as a helper and then continue searching the remaining parts of the City Museum together, but he had never expected to run into Nina right here.

In the next second, his gaze fell on Shirley.

So that meant… the voice he had heard through the mark earlier, the one talking with Shirley, had been Nina. The “classmate” Nina had mentioned who wanted to come along was Shirley?!

His mind quickly turned a corner, and Duncan understood. Then he noticed how fast Shirley’s expression changed. Before this Summoner, who seemed to have quite a bit of “fate” with him, could speak, he took a step forward, looked around, and said: “Looks like you are all fine.”

In the next second, he noticed there was actually a third person in the room: a young lady in a long dress lay unconscious on the floor, but she still seemed alive.

Shirley finally got her ability to think back. Her mind suddenly replayed everything Nina had just told her. After a long moment, she slowly turned her stiff neck, her face like she had seen a ghost, and said: “Nina… he is… your uncle?”

Nina said happily: “Yeah!” Then she rushed forward, threw herself at Duncan, and asked: “Uncle, how are you here?! Has the fire outside gone out?!”

Duncan answered offhand: “Not yet, but the fire is under control.” He knew such a vague statement would sound suspicious under normal circumstances, but right now Nina was clearly in a state of confusion. The still-shaken girl only clung tightly to his arm, repeating over and over: “That’s great, I thought today I was going to…”

Duncan cut Nina off and said: “Alright, whatever it is, we can talk after we get out. This isn’t the place for talking.” His gaze then swept over Shirley and the lady lying on the floor. “We need to take this lady with us.”

Nina reacted a bit late and said: “Ah… okay!” She hurried over to try to pull the lady up, and Shirley rushed over to help. But because of the difference in height, it was not easy for the two girls. So Duncan took a few steps forward, ready to do it himself.

But just as he reached out to help the lady up, something suddenly entered his sight and made him stop.

It was a purple crystal pendant that looked somewhat familiar.

Duncan paused for a moment and slowly recalled that home visit from old Mr. Morris M, and some things the man had mentioned in their talk.

Nina’s voice came from the side and broke his thoughts: “Uncle?”

Duncan shook his head lightly, glanced at Nina, then let his gaze casually sweep over Shirley at the side. He smiled slightly and said: “The world is small.”

After he spoke, he helped the lady up. With the two girls’ help, he hoisted her onto his back.

The group left the washroom. There were no more flames in the corridor outside, and even the thick smoke had, for “unknown reasons”, faded by more than half. Shirley looked at the dark passage ahead and hesitated before asking: “Which way do we go?”

Duncan raised his head and was about to point out a direction when he suddenly sensed something through the Power of Flame that had spread through the City Museum earlier. His thoughts moved, and he changed his original plan, striding toward another exit to the side and saying: “This way.”

With the fire itself retreating and guiding them, they quickly left the place. Not long after they were gone, a squad of figures suddenly came around the bend in the corridor ahead and appeared near the washroom.

It was the Deep Sea Church Guardian squad that had rushed into the blaze earlier.

The squad members were covered in soot, but the ocean divine blessing on them had not yet faded. They had charged in ready to die, yet the flames in the City Museum had suddenly died down so fast that they came out unharmed.

The leading priest frowned slightly as he looked around and muttered: “The fire here is out too… even the smoke has dispersed.”

One Guardian said quietly: “Fire going out is a good thing.”

The priest spoke in a low voice: “It is a good thing, but under normal circumstances a fire of this size doesn’t go out so easily.” As he spoke, he suddenly noticed the washroom door nearby that had been smashed in.

A Guardian stepped forward at once to inspect it and said: “Someone has been here…” After confirming the marks around the doorway, he deftly took out a censer and a prayer book, and then put a Custom Lens Harness on his head.

The lens array looked like half a helmet made of copper tubes, cranks, and a series of lenses. On the edges of some lenses, one could see complex runes etched into the glass.

The Guardian set the censer on the ground, then adjusted the lenses on his head and began to examine all the remaining traces nearby.

He reported quickly: “No supernatural power left behind… they were a few ordinary people. I can’t tell the exact number; their traces are very mixed. It should be the visitors who were trapped earlier… The door was broken inward. It looks like someone outside smashed it open and rescued them.”

The priest asked: “No supernatural power, confirmed?”

The Guardian replied: “None.”

The priest said: “…Keep searching upward.”

“Yes!”

Chapter 121: Miss Psychiatrist

At an emergency exit on the west side of the City Museum, Duncan led Nina and Shirley out. When fresh air and bright daylight hit them together, Shirley could not help being the first to cheer: “Yes! We got out!”

Duncan glanced at the girl, but before he could say anything, he suddenly felt the young lady on his back move a little. The fresh air and the jolting along the way had finally woken her up.

Duncan quickly found a spot nearby and let her down from his back.

Heidi slowly came to.

Pain. Her forehead hurt as if someone had hit it with a brick, and then came the discomfort in her lungs from breathing in some smoke. Those were Heidi’s first sensations as her consciousness returned. Then she suddenly opened her eyes and began to cough violently.

Only after the confusion and the harsh coughing did she suddenly realize she had been saved. She was somewhere outside the City Museum. Bright sunlight and fresh air surrounded her, and several figures stood in front of her.

Nina crouched down beside the young lady, looked at Heidi with concern as she opened her eyes and tried to get used to the light, and said: “You’re awake. How do you feel? Does anything hurt?”

Heidi’s eyes finally focused and adapted to the bright light outside. She quickly judged the situation and recognized the two young girls in front of

her and said: “My head hurts… Did you save me? Ah, it’s you two…”

Shirley froze for a moment and blurted out: “You know us?”

Heidi shook her head as she sat up and looked around, coughing twice, and said: “I don’t. But I remember seeing you in the City Museum.”

Nina spoke quickly: “You were knocked out. Shirley and I dragged you to a safer place for the moment. Then my uncle rushed into the fire to save people and carried you out too. You’re safe now.”

Heidi’s gaze quickly fell on Duncan. She spoke while trying to stand up, as if wanting to bow in thanks: “Your uncle… ah, is it this mister? Thank you…” But before she could finish the motion, she almost fell again.

Duncan caught her and steadied her and said: “No need to be so polite.”

Heidi stood there weakly, bowing her head in gratitude and lingering fear, and said: “Thank you. If it weren’t for you, I would have burned to death in there for sure… This fire was terrifying… I’m so grateful. I really don’t know how I should…”

Duncan smiled at the lady and said: “You don’t need to be so formal. We actually have a bit of a connection… Do you know Mr. Morris M?”

Heidi froze for a moment and looked at Duncan in confusion and said: “That’s my father… You know him?”

Duncan pointed at the purple ‘crystal’ pendant on Heidi’s chest and said: “This pendant of yours is something you took from my shop.”

Heidi glanced down at the pendant on her chest, her expression going blank: “…Huh?!”

Duncan laughed and held out his hand and said: “Small world, isn’t it? Let me introduce myself properly. I’m Duncan Strayne. I run an antique shop in the Lower City. This is my niece, Nina, and this here is…”

Shirley jumped in at once, as if afraid that if she was a step late, her name would come out of some very terrifying being's mouth and pick up the curse or something like that, and said: "I'm Shirley! You… you can just call me Shirley!"

Heidi took Duncan's hand. Her head still felt a bit dizzy, but she did her best to pull herself together and said: "Heidi Underwood. I'm a psychiatrist."

Duncan raised his eyebrows without thinking and asked: "A psychiatrist? You're a psychiatrist?"

Heidi said with some pride: "Ah, yes. I may look a bit young… but I'm a psychiatrist with an Advanced License." She then started patting herself down and finally dug out a wrinkled business card. She held the card out to Duncan with both hands and said: "This is my business card. If it can be of use, I'm always willing to provide free consultations for you…"

A psychiatrist from the Upper City with an Advanced License really might be a useful connection.

Duncan took the business card and glanced at it. It listed the address of a clinic in the Upper City, Heidi's name, her license number, and a line of code made up of five numbers and letters.

Before that line of code, there was a note: "express dispatch code".

Duncan's gaze lingered on the "express dispatch code" for a moment. He remembered that it seemed to be part of Pland's postal system, but not the same as ordinary letters. He vaguely recalled seeing special facilities for sending and receiving "express dispatches" somewhere in the Lower City, but the original Master of this body had never actually used them.

They were expensive. The postage cost almost ten times that of normal letters, and the original Master of this body had no relatives or friends

worth spending that kind of money to contact in a hurry.

Duncan only roughly knew that this special kind of “mail” used High-Pressure Steam Conduits and Standard Capsule Pods for fast delivery. It could carry not only letters but also small parcels. Even counting the manual handling at the ends and any possible delivery delays, it took at most a few hours to send something to any corner of the city-state.

What could he say… He could only sigh that she really was a high-end psychiatrist from the Upper City, even using such expensive things just to take appointment requests…

After quietly sighing to himself, Duncan put the business card away carefully. Then he heard Heidi suddenly speak: “By the way, do you need… post-disaster mental evaluations?”

Duncan gave her a puzzled look, and the young Miss Psychiatrist quickly explained: “Of course it’s free—I don’t mean anything else by it. It’s just that after an accident, people’s minds are very easy to hurt. Especially in a place like the City Museum, where there are many exhibits with historical attributes. Heavy mental stress plus the influence of certain items… it’s easy to leave shadows on the mind.”

Heidi seemed to be choosing her words carefully. She wanted to share some very professional, high-level “knowledge” that was even a bit removed from ordinary life with the people in front of her, but she also worried that this kind of “popular science” might be insulting. So she tried her best to sound sincere and gentle. Duncan could see her effort, but what he was thinking about was something else—

He himself certainly did not need any mental evaluation. After being a “captain” for so long, he was well aware of how special he was. Forget some mental pressure from a fire like this—even if something crawled out

of the Abyssal Deep Sea, to say hello to him, the one who would need a sanity check afterward would be the other side.

As for Shirley… a tough girl who could swing Abyssal demons around and fight cultists for three hundred rounds hardly needed a mental evaluation. The mental shock she got from this whole fire was probably smaller than the shadow left in her heart when she saw him kick the door open…

But Nina… Nina might really need a psychiatrist's help.

It was not just because of today's fire. It was more because of her poor mental state these days and those dreams that felt a lot like prophetic visions.

This needed a professional to handle. His own power was useless in this field. Before, he and Nina had discussed going to the Cathedral when they had a chance, but now that a high-level psychiatrist was willing to help… it would be a waste not to use it.

Duncan glanced at his "niece", reached out to ruffle the girl's hair, and said: "Nina might need help. But not just because of today's fire—she's been having strange dreams lately, and her mental state is very poor."

Nina muttered at once: "I'm actually fine…"

Heidi smiled, pointed at herself, and said: "It's free. My usual consultation fee is…" She accidentally poked the place where the brick had hit her and cried out: "Ow, ow, ow!"

A big lump had swollen up where the brick had hit her forehead, and it hurt whenever she touched it.

Shirley, who had been quiet for a long time, joined in the fun and said: "Exactly, it's free. Don't waste it. She still owes us a favor anyway…"

Nina hesitated for a moment and finally nodded slightly and said: “Then… alright.” But then she looked at Heidi in confusion. “What do you need for a mental evaluation? Can we do it here? Do I have to answer some questions? Or fill out forms?”

Heidi explained with a smile: “We at least need a quiet environment, and I need to be in better shape—at least until this big bump on my head goes down a bit. I’m a professional, not like those lousy doctors who write you a diagnosis report after asking a few random questions. How about this: tomorrow is a school rest day. If Miss Nina has time, I’ll visit you in the afternoon. I’ll ask my father for your address.”

She paused as she spoke and gently touched the wound on her forehead.

She said: “As for now, I need to find a place to treat this wound first… hiss…”

Duncan thought for a moment and said: “There are constables keeping order at the square, and there are medical staff there too. Do you need us to go with you? In your current state…”

Heidi waved her hand and said: “No need. I’m completely awake now.” She then looked back at the City Museum, which was still sending up faint smoke. A trace of lingering fear and undisguised regret came to her face. “Sigh… my rare day off… completely ruined.”

Duncan said casually: “Having a ruined day off really is a terrible thing. But the good thing is we just survived a disaster, right?”

Heidi spoke, then sighed again and muttered: “Alright… that’s true when you put it that way. Sigh, I just hope certain heretic elements and moving Calamities can behave themselves a bit. Then at least my next day off might come a little sooner… Ah, sorry, I shouldn’t complain about this in front of strangers. Please don’t mind me.”

Duncan said: “…?”

Chapter 122: The Figure at the Edge of the Square

After asking clearly where the relief station near the square was, Heidi left on her own, holding her head. Duncan, however, had no intention of going over to deal with the official personnel there—mainly because Shirley was standing beside him now, and this girl who could summon Abyssal demons clearly did not want to have anything to do with the Deep Sea Church.

He watched Heidi's figure grow smaller in the distance and let out a soft breath. Then he turned to Nina first: "You didn't get hurt, did you?"

"No." Nina was still a little shaken. She had been unconsciously clutching Duncan's sleeve, and only now suddenly realized it and let go. Then she looked at Duncan in surprise. "You still haven't told me. Why did you show up at the City Museum?"

"I happened to be dealing with something nearby," Duncan said with a smile. "Then I suddenly heard the City Museum was on fire, so I came to save you."

Before she could say anything else, he reached out and rubbed the girl's hair, comforting the recently frightened Nina: "All right, it's over. As long as you aren't hurt."

"…I'm not a little child anymore!" Nina shook her head. Then her gaze fell on Shirley, who was standing beside her. She was about to speak when a strange look suddenly appeared on her face, as if she had remembered

something that didn’t quite fit. She looked Shirley up and down. “Shirley… why do I suddenly feel… that you’re a bit…”

A moment ago, Shirley’s attention had been completely on Duncan. Now, when she saw Nina’s reaction, panic showed plainly on her face. Her eyes opened a little wider. In her fluster she glanced at Duncan, and there was even more fear in her expression.

Duncan’s heart stirred when he saw this change, because this young lady’s face looked exactly the same as when she had been caught skipping the tram fare. He glanced thoughtfully at Nina and went back over, in his mind, how he had dealt with Shirley before and what identity she was playing now—

Known facts: both times he had dealt with Shirley were when Nina was in class at school. Also known: Shirley’s real personality was awful, rough, and hot-tempered, nothing like a “quiet, well?behaved child.” Also known: one of Dog’s abilities as a Abyssal demon was to interfere with an ordinary person’s judgment to maintain a disguise…

And her current “identity” was Nina’s new friend at school. That identity was full of holes.

Duncan rubbed his chin, set a hand on Nina’s shoulder, and jerked his chin toward Shirley. “Do you really know her?”

“Of course. Her name is Shirley. She’s a new friend I made, but…” Nina frowned. “But for some reason, just now I suddenly couldn’t remember when she showed up at school…”

Duncan turned his head and let his gaze rest quietly on Shirley, who was already trying hard to lower her presence. After a long moment he spoke softly: “You still have a chance to explain yourself, or I…”

He had barely finished speaking when Shirley burst out in a rapid rush of words: “I’m sorry, I was wrong, I only slipped into the school because I wanted to investigate something, but I really didn’t hurt Nina, and just now in the City Museum I even blocked the falling beam for her, please believe me, I really didn’t know she was your retainer, I don’t know what a big shot like you is into, please, just let me—”

Duncan hadn’t even had time to say the rest before he was stunned by this barrage from the girl who had once swung a dog around, her voice on the verge of tears. His first reaction was that this girl was incredibly gifted and might even serve as a good sparring partner for Goathead…

Then he cleared his throat twice and cut off Shirley’s babbling. “She’s not a retainer. She’s my niece.”

As he spoke, his gaze fell on Shirley’s hands.

They bore signs of burns. Thanks to her amazing healing, only faint scars were left, but she really did seem to have been hurt in the City Museum.

If she wasn’t lying—and she probably didn’t dare—then she really had done it to protect Nina.

Shirley, of course, had no idea what Duncan was thinking. Her mind was almost blank. “If… if you say she’s your niece, then she’s your niece…”

Only then did Nina slowly react. She looked at her uncle in surprise, then at the “friend” in front of her. “Wait, you two… already know each other? And Shirley, why did you—”

“By chance,” Duncan said calmly. He did not let Shirley speak, because who knew what this girl might blurt out in front of Nina. “Looks like we have a lot to talk about. Don’t you think so, Shirley?”

Shirley was almost in tears. She looked at Duncan with a long face. “If you say so, then—”

“You say so.”

“…Yes, that’s right.”

“Uncle, don’t be so fierce to Shirley,” Nina said. She was still completely confused, but she could see that, for some reason, this new friend was very afraid of her uncle, and her uncle was not being very polite to Shirley either. That made her uneasy and puzzled at the same time. “My head is a mess right now… can someone explain what is going on?”

“We’ll talk slowly when we get home,” Duncan sighed. He looked up at the City Museum, which was still sending out smoke, then turned in the direction he had come from. “It’s too chaotic here. And the two of you are covered in soot. We need to go back, wash up, and change clothes.”

Shirley stammered, “I… I’m coming too?”

Then, before Duncan could answer, she nodded hard to herself. “You’re right!”

Duncan sighed, half helpless and half amused. No matter why Shirley had approached Nina at first, from now on she would definitely be harmless at Nina’s side. He shook his head and prepared to leave with the two girls.

Just then, his gaze happened to sweep over the edge of the City Museum square.

A figure standing near the crowd at the edge of the square suddenly caught his eye.

It was a figure in a black coat, back turned to them, looking toward the burning building. From the back, it seemed to be a tall, thin man. His coat looked like a long trench coat, its long hem almost covering his whole body. The strangest part was that he was holding a large black umbrella on this bright, sunny day.

There was no wind and no rain, and the sunlight was not even very strong. Yet a tall, thin man in a long coat stood at the edge of the square under an open umbrella, watching the fire. No matter where you put it, that scene would look strange. But many people were gathered at the edge of the square, and not a single one was looking in the direction of the man with the umbrella.

“Uncle?” Nina noticed Duncan suddenly stop and looked curiously toward where he was staring. “Is something over there?”

“There is a man over there holding an umbrella on a sunny day. It’s very strange,” Duncan said casually.

“A man with an umbrella on a sunny day?” Nina froze. “Where? I don’t see him…”

“I don’t see him either,” Shirley said, rubbing her eyes and following Duncan’s line of sight with curiosity. “Maybe your eyes are playing tricks on you…”

“You both can’t see him?” Duncan’s brow furrowed at once. He glanced at Shirley and Nina, then turned his eyes back toward the square—and in that instant, the man with the umbrella had already vanished.

“Uncle?” Nina looked at Duncan, worried. “Did you breathe in too much smoke just now? Are you feeling sick?”

“…I’m fine. Maybe my eyes just played a trick on me.” Duncan only shook his head and answered lightly so Nina would not worry.

But his gaze still stayed on the square. Before he finally looked away, he fixed his gaze on that spot one last time.

If it was only a strange man with an umbrella, then it was no big deal.

But if it was a figure only he could see, that was a different matter.

He remembered that figure.

…

Vanna led a squad of elite guardians to the Ocean City Museum, but by the time she arrived, the sudden blaze was already nearing its end.

A soot?covered Deep Sea priest came up to the Inquisitor with several guardian warriors who had also just rushed out of the fire.

“The fire suddenly died down on its own,” the Deep Sea priest reported at once after saluting Vanna. “But we didn’t find any traces of supernatural power left at the scene.”

“Died down on its own?” Vanna’s face grew serious at the report. “…You led the team into the fire. Did you find anything odd?”

“Among the citizens fleeing the scene, there was a large number showing extreme panic, hallucinations, and babbling. I suspect there is supernatural corruption in the City Museum,” the priest said with a nod. “But we searched the place and found nothing… The only abnormal thing was that the flames suddenly died down on their own.”

As he spoke, the priest made a gesture of prayer to the Goddess and added, “But it was also because the fire faded that the guardians and I were able to retreat safely.”

Vanna thought for a moment and nodded slightly. “All right. When the fire is completely out, I’ll have people search the City Museum again from top to bottom, to see if any exhibits have changed…”

After giving these brief orders, the young Inquisitor raised her head. Her gaze swept over the citizens who were receiving aid and mental guidance, as if she were searching for someone in the crowd.

Just then, a voice called from not far away: “Vanna! I’m here!”

Vanna looked up and saw the bedraggled Heidi waving hard at her from the crowd.

Chapter 123: Sealed in Memory

Heidi ran up to Vanna, out of breath. Nearby guardians reflexively moved to block her when they saw her approach, but they soon recognized that this disheveled, soot?covered miss was the senior advisor to the City Hall and the Church, so they let her pass at once.

“So you personally led the team?” Heidi looked in surprise at the fully armed Vanna, then glanced at the elite church troops behind her. “And you brought so many people?”

“A fire at the City Museum isn’t an ordinary incident,” Vanna said briefly. Then she looked Heidi up and down several times, and only relaxed after confirming that her friend was unharmed. “Looks like your vacation is ruined.”

“It’s ruined again!” Heidi said, her face full of sorrow and resignation. “Why am I always this unlucky… ah, ow…”

Vanna noticed the unusual lump on Heidi’s head. She stepped forward, laid her fingers lightly near the wound, and at the same time looked toward the direction Heidi had run from. Her brows drew together slightly. “Did you just escape from there?”

“I was rescued by someone… ah, that feels much better…” As the pain in her forehead slowly faded, Heidi’s thoughts also began to clear. Then she froze for a moment, as if she had suddenly recalled something. She quickly looked around, then hurried close to Vanna. “I need a quiet place under a divine blessing, preferably inside the Cathedral.”

Seeing her friend suddenly grow serious, Vanna reacted at once. She did not ask anything. Instead, she turned to the priests she had brought. “Take over order at the scene. Seal off the City Museum. Raise the corruption level to Spirit Realm—”

She had not finished when Heidi spoke in a low, urgent voice: “Abyssal Deep level.”

“Adjust it to Abyssal Deep level. Clear all ordinary people within two hundred meters of the square!” Vanna’s heart lurched, and she gave her orders at once. Then she turned to the bearded local priest. “Take us to the nearest Cathedral. We need a separate prayer room—prepare No.16 Sacramental Incense.”

The priest who had just escaped the fire bowed his head at once. “Yes. Please follow me. It’s near the square.”

Vanna took Heidi away from the square at once. Together with the guiding priest, they rode toward the community Cathedral near the plaza. Before they arrived, Vanna noticed that Heidi’s face had started to flush in an abnormal way.

“What’s happening?” Vanna frowned and touched Heidi’s forehead. The burning heat beneath her fingers made her voice change at once. “Why are you this hot?!”

“I may have come into contact with something in the City Museum,” Heidi said quickly. “I used self?hypnosis to seal some information in the depths of my memory. The hypnosis just wore off… I’m starting to remember it bit by bit.”

As she listened, Vanna’s eyes widened slightly, and in her heart she quickly reached a judgment—

Severe supernatural manifestation and corruption, able to affect the Mortal Realm world through cognition alone.

“Stop remembering at once. Slow your thoughts,” Vanna said, pressing a hand on Heidi’s shoulder. “Look into my eyes. Shift your attention somewhere else. If you can’t, then hypnotize yourself again!”

“I’ll try.” Heidi took a slow breath and fixed her gaze on Vanna’s eyes, deep and calm like the sea. She tried hard to control the memories rising in her mind, to keep herself from recalling that vast and solemn river of fire, that sea of flames surging and rolling in the dark void. But the memories still leaked out bit by bit, like blood seeping from a wound, impossible to stop.

Suddenly, a faint coolness rose from her chest, and Heidi, who had felt as if she were about to be swallowed by fire, came to herself a little.

She looked down by instinct and saw that the glass “crystal pendant” that could only count as a free trinket in a Lower City antique shop was glowing faintly on her chest.

That tiny bit of light was almost impossible to see with the naked eye, yet it was like an anchor rooted firmly in the Mortal Realm, pulling her scattered spirit back together.

The next second, she heard the priest’s voice from the front. “We’ve reached the Cathedral!”

With the powerful Saint Vanna personally escorting her, Heidi was rushed into the Cathedral. Thanks to the priest’s earlier Psychic Transmission to the Cathedral, a prayer room had already been prepared, and incense with strong soothing and protective effects was burning.

In the faint smoke from the incense, the holy statue of the storm Goddess Gamona looked down quietly at Heidi and Vanna as they hurried into the room.

The priest was left outside the prayer room—because he might not be able to withstand the mental corruption that could follow.

As Heidi stepped into the prayer room, Vanna heard unreal waves crash by her ears. A feeling as if a supreme, great being was directly casting a gaze over her swept across her soul. Right after that, every lamp and candle in the Cathedral flared up, roaring, their flames laced with sharp crackles!

She looked up at the statue of the storm Goddess and saw it suddenly grow distant yet towering. An indescribable air of majesty poured out from the statue and slowly gathered around Heidi.

“The Lord has cast a gaze…” The manifestations in the prayer room made Vanna’s heart jump, but then she slowly let out a breath. She looked at Heidi and saw that the flush on her face was fading. “You are safe now. Release your memories. Let us see what you saw.”

Heidi did not speak. She only nodded lightly, then took off one of her earrings. There was a tiny shifting mechanism at its end. She pressed it with a fingernail, and a spike only a few millimeters long popped out.

Without a trace of hesitation, she gripped the earring tightly, letting fresh blood seep into her palm.

This was the deepest mental suggestion she had planted in herself when she first became a psychiatrist—when the Platinum Spike pierced her palm, all unclean things sealed in her memory could be released.

In the next second, the unreal, layered sound of waves in the prayer room suddenly grew very clear, while all the burning candles turned dim and flickering. It was as if the whole room were covered in shifting, blurry veils. Those veils rippled layer upon layer around the Goddess’s statue, and within them vague phantoms appeared—

It was a scene Heidi had urgently sealed inside her own memory.

It was only the instant truth she had glimpsed in a single flash.

In those swaying, unreal veils, Vanna saw what Heidi had seen before:

In a pitch?black void, a column of flame shot up, more blazing than any fire in the world, more shocking than any power humans had ever created. It was like a towering wave of flame sweeping out to devour all things, and even someone like Vanna, the Saint, felt every muscle in her body tighten the moment she saw it!

How far did that flame surge through the darkness? Hundreds of thousands of kilometers? A million? Even farther?

What was that? Pure fire? Or something more primal than fire, a kind of power that could touch truth from before time?

Vanna did not know when she had stopped breathing. She watched the stream of fire rise in the darkness, then slowly fall. The flowing fire was like thick ointment, forming a grand, ragged arc in the empty dark. Only when the vision slowly faded, and the unreal layered sound of waves eased around her, did she begin to recover her senses.

She did not know how much time passed before she suddenly felt something like sea wind moistening her thoughts. The storm Goddess's gentle comfort woke her. She looked at Heidi and found that Heidi too was staring at her in shock, as if fixing a gaze on her.

"This… is what you saw in the City Museum?"

"Maybe… I think so…" Heidi's heart pounded. Even though this scene had been drawn from her own memory, the way self?hypnosis worked still made it feel beyond anything she had imagined. "But this thing… doesn't seem like the kind of 'exhibit' you can keep in a single City Museum…"

"This can't be any kind of 'exhibit'," Vanna said quickly. "Even if we can't judge how large it really is, I know by instinct that it can't be stored inside

any building… You could not have seen it in the Mortal Realm.”

Heidi paused, her brows tightly knitted. After a long time she spoke, unsure. “I might have seen it while I was unconscious… and done the self?hypnosis while I was unconscious. What I saw may not have been its real body, but its ‘projection’ on the spiritual level.”

“Are you sure?” Vanna looked at her. “I’m not questioning your skill as a psychiatrist, but… finishing a temporary containment seal against mental corruption while unconscious is not easy.”

“I am confident,” Heidi said, nodding slowly but firmly. “I received strict training in this field at Truth Academy. I can rely on my subconscious to complete the containment of dangerous information even when my main consciousness is in a runaway state. But because self?hypnosis in that state is uncontrollable, it makes me forget many key details. So I can’t tell you the exact circumstances under which I saw this ‘projection’, or what the trigger or medium was.”

“…All right. I believe in your professional skill,” Vanna said, staring at Heidi for a while before letting out a slow breath. “It seems… you really did see something truly extraordinary.”

Chapter 124: The Fragment’s Reflection

Incense burned in the prayer room under the divine gaze of the Goddess’s statue. The two longtime friends fell silent at the same time. Only the divine blessing sent down by the God gently soothed their still-frightened hearts. A faint, calm sound of waves echoed in Vanna’s ears. It was the whisper of the storm Goddess Gamona.

The Goddess still watched this place, with an attention unlike ever before.

After who knew how long, Heidi finally calmed down. She carefully broke the silence: “What exactly did I see?”

Vanna hesitated for a moment before speaking softly: “Maybe… that was exactly what those Suntists have been searching for.”

“What those Suntists have been searching for?” Heidi froze for a moment. “You mean…”

“The Sun fragment,” Vanna nodded lightly before Heidi could finish. “Maybe only a Sun fragment could match the power you saw in that vision.”

As she spoke, Vanna slowly lifted her head and looked up at the statue of the storm Goddess, murmuring thoughtfully: “After all… those Heretics claim that the Sun fragments are the remains that fell from the so-called ‘true Sun’…”

Heidi paused, and her expression changed slightly: “If something like that really appeared in the Mortal Realm, the city-state of Pland couldn’t still be as safe as it looks now…”

“So it must have been under some kind of seal,” Vanna nodded. “Our information says a Sun fragment appeared in the city-state of Pland eleven years ago. But now it seems that so-called ‘appearance’ was only a bit of its power leaking out. For the past eleven years, it has probably stayed asleep…”

“And now those Suntists want to wake that thing up?!” Heidi looked horrified. “Do they want to destroy all of Pland?!”

“It’s not your first day dealing with cultists,” Vanna glanced at Heidi. “You still don’t understand their state of mind? For those fanatical Heretics, as long as they can awaken the ‘Black Sun’, sacrificing one or two city-states in a sacrificial rite is nothing. They wouldn’t even mind letting the whole world burn, just to become kindling for the Sun God’s recovery!”

Heidi opened her mouth but did not speak for a long time. Vanna steadied her own emotions, then slowly said: “The key now is what exactly happened when you saw that vision—what happened to you, what happened around you, and what happened inside The City Museum itself. Only by figuring these out can we know in what state that fragment is sleeping, and where it is actually sleeping.”

“…No, I can’t remember the details,” Heidi tapped her forehead lightly. “But I can now be sure that I really saw its projection while I was unconscious, and that I put myself under emergency hypnosis to preserve the important clues… Let me think. At the time, someone rescued me and temporarily placed me in a room on the first floor of The City Museum… After I came out, they told me that room was close to the main exhibition hall…”

As Heidi struggled to recall, she asked, thinking aloud: “Can’t we take this to mean that the clue is inside The City Museum?”

“It’s hard to say. From the viewpoint of occult studies, what you saw was not the fragment itself, but a little ‘shadow’ leaking from a huge supernatural existence into the Mortal Realm. The City Museum is not necessarily where the fragment sleeps. There might only be a ‘rift’ there, and because the mental defenses of humans are weak while they are unconscious, your mind accidentally crossed that rift and saw what lies on the other side.

“Rifts that hover at the edge of the Mortal Realm are often unstable. It might have been at The City Museum before, but now it may have already shifted somewhere else.”

Vanna explained patiently, then suddenly shook her head: “Of course, we will still carry out a top-level search of The City Museum and keep it under watch afterward. Anomalies and Visions are always irregular. It’s possible that the fragment really stayed in The City Museum in some sealed form. Even if it did not, we might still find some clues in the burned ruins to explain why the ‘rift’ appeared at The City Museum in the first place…”

“But the follow-up search has nothing to do with you. For safety, you’d better stay away from The City Museum for the next month.”

“Of course, I’d love to keep my distance from all this,” Heidi nodded at once. “I’ve already had more than enough bad luck!”

Vanna silently looked at this friend who had been unlucky since childhood. She seemed about to say something, but in the end she said nothing. She simply stood there under the Goddess’s statue in silence. After half a minute, she suddenly asked: “Who rescued you?”

“Two girls still in school, and a man who looked to be in his forties,” Heidi thought for a moment. “Funny enough, one of those girls is exactly the student my father visited at home a few days ago, and the man is her uncle… I told you about him, right? His name is Duncan Strayne. He is an antique shopkeeper.”

“…I’m a little allergic to the name ‘Duncan’ right now,” Vanna’s mouth visibly twitched. “Even though I know it can’t be the same person…”

“My reaction was the same when I first heard that name from my father,” Heidi spread her hands. “Speaking of that, I promised that gentleman I would go to his place tomorrow afternoon to give his niece a psychological evaluation, and it will also be a proper visit to thank him. Everything was a mess today, and I said goodbye in a hurry. It really wasn’t very polite.”

“Strictly speaking, it’s not only that ‘niece’ who needs a psychological evaluation,” Vanna’s expression suddenly turned serious. She stared straight at Heidi. “All three of them do.”

“Why…” Heidi spoke without thinking, then suddenly realized. “Ah!”

“Right. They were all next to you at the time, and you saw the shape of the Sun fragment while you were unconscious,” Vanna looked straight into Heidi’s eyes. “If that really was the remains of one of the Elder Gods, its corruption may have already spread to them through your mind. The scope of that corruption might be small, but for an ordinary person, it could still be fatal.”

Heidi was stunned.

…

In the Lower City’s antique shop, Duncan had already closed up early. He sat in a relaxed posture on the chair behind the counter, while Nina and Shirley sat facing him, one on each side.

The two of them had taken a shower in the simple bathroom upstairs. Nina had changed into clean clothes, but Shirley still wore her black dress—not because Nina refused to lend her clothes, but because their body sizes were too different. Shirley herself had turned down those outfits that would hang far too loose on her.

Of course, whether she had other worries when she refused was another matter… Maybe Shirley thought that taking Nina's clothes would be like accepting a gift from an Eldritch God's retainer. Only she knew for sure.

On the other side of the counter, the pigeon AI was strolling about at ease.

A big pile of fries was stacked on the table behind it—that was what Duncan had promised it.

AI had finally gotten the fries it had been longing for. Nina had come home safe and sound. Duncan had rescued his niece and had become even more familiar with the Power of Flame.

Everyone was happy.

Except Shirley.

She was almost in tears—she had wanted to cry several times today.

"So… Shirley, you actually aren't my classmate… You just used some kind of 'detective trick' to sneak into the school and investigate something," Nina looked at the friend she had finally managed to make, her expression a bit complicated. "You don't even like steam and machinery…"

"I can't even understand those textbooks at all…" Shirley spoke carefully. She answered Nina, but her eyes kept drifting toward Duncan from time to time. "Sorry, I… I'm sorry."

But Nina seemed not to notice Shirley's apology. She only frowned in confusion: "But how did you do it? I… thinking back now, you always

suddenly appeared in my classroom, and you often showed up around me, but you never really attended class. Even the teachers and classmates nearby never seemed to notice you, you…”

Shirley quickly glanced at Duncan again. After she confirmed that his expression was still calm, she muttered under her breath: “It was actually just a little supernatural trick…”

“supernatural?” Nina’s eyes widened in surprise. “Are you a Church investigator?”

“No, no, I’m not with the Church, I…” Shirley stole another look at Duncan. She remembered the warnings this big boss had given her earlier when Nina went upstairs to bathe. She still had no idea why this big boss wanted to play a ‘pretend to be human’ game in this antique shop, but she still obeyed his orders honestly. “I’m more like a wild… a wild supernatural…”

Nina looked utterly shocked. “…There are wild supernatural too?!”

“If you’re not registered anywhere, then you’re wild,” Shirley spoke as if she had given up on something, her tone a little reckless. “The dogs in the Church… those troublesome people, isn’t that what they usually call people like us?”

Nina listened to Shirley’s explanation in a daze. Then Nina looked her up and down several times. That careful gaze made Shirley feel very uneasy, and she instinctively tried to dodge: “Why are you looking at me like that…”

“Then you’re amazing!” Nina suddenly said, very seriously.

Chapter 125: Getting to Know Each Other

Nina’s attention seemed stuck on a very strange point, but for Shirley, that was a good thing.

Shirley had already, deep down, started to see this seemingly simple, ordinary girl as the retainer of some Subspace Shadows, and not just any retainer, but a cherished-daughter-level retainer. The fewer bad impressions Shirley left in front of this retainer, the better her odds of surviving when she faced the big boss.

Nina had no idea how many worries hid behind Shirley’s stiff, awkward smile. The young lady was now both amazed and a little excited, because she had never been this close to a real supernatural before (her usual visits to the Cathedral did not count). What she knew about such things came only from books, and in her eyes, Shirley, who had used some kind of “supernatural illusion” to slip into the school and investigate, was now surrounded by a mysterious and powerful glow.

She even forgot, for a while, about Shirley’s small “deception” toward her, and instead put all her attention on the unusual life and adventures of an supernatural—even if those adventures were mostly things Nina made up herself: “Where do you usually live? Do you have your own secret base or something? Or a very mysterious organization?

“Do you usually hide in caves? Or in sewers? Do you have some warehouse-like place to store all kinds of ritual items?

“Were you born with special powers? Or do you have some powerful supernatural item? Are you one of those legendary ‘Arcanists’? I heard there is an ancient profession like that. Arcanists can cast spells without relying on any god. They say their power comes from their bloodline…

“What do you usually eat? Do you have to drink herbal brews or strange animal blood all the time? Huh? You eat normal food too? Really?”

Nina’s questions came one after another, crackling on without end. By the time Shirley answered half of them, sweat had already formed on her forehead—not because she could not answer, but because Duncan was sitting right beside them!

From the start, Duncan had been quietly watching Shirley, with a warm and gentle smile—on the surface, he looked just like a parent who showed up to greet a child’s classmate visiting the house.

Plain, kind, completely harmless.

But every time he smiled, Shirley broke out in a new layer of cold sweat.

“You seem really scared of my uncle,” even Nina, slow as she was in such things, noticed Shirley’s strange behavior. When she also recalled Shirley’s reaction back at The City Museum, she could not help asking: “What exactly happened between you two?”

“N-nothing! Really!” Shirley almost jolted upright in her seat, waving her hands hard. “What… what could happen between me and your uncle, I’m still a child…”

When Duncan heard that, he felt something sounded off. He knew he could not let the two young ladies keep going on their own. Before Shirley’s wild talk got any worse, he coughed twice to interrupt: “It really was nothing. She just tried to ride without a ticket once, and I happened to catch her.”

“Just because of that?” Nina looked at Shirley in surprise. “That shouldn’t leave such a big shadow, right… But Uncle is right, fare-dodging is bad.”

Shirley was almost in tears. “I really won’t dodge tickets anymore, okay?!”

Nina nodded, then suddenly seemed to think of something. She looked at Shirley very seriously: “Then… can you tell me what you’re actually investigating? Did you become friends with me because of your ‘investigation’?”

Shirley’s back went ramrod straight, and her eyes started to drift to the side, but halfway over they met Duncan’s calm gaze.

“I am investigating the fire from eleven years ago,” Shirley suddenly lowered her head a little, as if something had finally clicked in her mind—or as if she had just decided to give up. Her voice dropped. “The one in the official records, the factory leak incident in the Sixth District…”

“The fire from eleven years ago?” Nina’s eyes went wide at once, her tone full of shock. “Wait… you know about that big fire too?!”

“…You know too?!” Shirley also looked shocked. She stood up straight from the chair. “You went through that fire as well?”

“Of course I know. My parents died in that fire—that year I was six, and Uncle Duncan was the one who saved me,” Nina spoke quickly, gesturing without thinking. “But all this time, everyone said the poisonous smoke in the streets confused me. They all said there was no big fire at all. Even the later newspapers said it was just a factory accident…”

“That year… I was six too. My parents also died in the fire. I remember it clearly,” Shirley stared straight into Nina’s eyes. “But the people around me also told me there was no fire back then… No wonder, no wonder Dog said it smelled a familiar scent on you…”

As soon as she finished, Duncan's voice came from the side: "So it was Dog that led you toward Nina, and that's why you slipped into the school—and you didn't know why you had to do it, so you were just as shocked when you heard Nina just now."

Meeting Duncan's calm gaze, Shirley quickly nodded. Nina, however, looked puzzled: "Dog? Who is Dog?"

"Dog is…" Shirley began, then hesitated the next second. She glanced at Duncan, then at Nina. "Dog is my friend. It's right beside me, but its appearance might be a little scary…"

As Shirley said this, she felt extremely strange inside—because there was clearly a Subspace Shadows sitting right here that was countless times scarier than Dog, and this Subspace Shadows even lived with Nina day and night. Yet she had to go along with the big boss's "personal hobby", pretend that Dog was the scariest thing here, and treat the big boss as an ordinary person…

To be fair, in her daily life Shirley used Dog's disguise ability to move around everywhere. She had dealt with cultists, with constables, and even with priests from small local Cathedrals. But all of that put together was not as tense and frightening as sitting in this antique shop for ten minutes.

In her eyes, this ordinary-looking shop was almost on the same level as an entrance to the Subspace.

Nina only looked around curiously, trying to find a sign of "Dog" near Shirley. After peering about for quite a while, she finally asked in curiosity: "Then let 'Dog' come out and meet me. Since it's your friend… what is there to be afraid of?"

Shirley was still a little hesitant, but Duncan suddenly tapped the table lightly and said to Nina: "Then you have to be mentally prepared. I've seen

Dog. It’s really ugly.”

“…Now I’m even more curious,” when Nina saw the reactions of Uncle Duncan and Shirley, her curiosity only grew. “I really want to meet this ‘Mr. Dog’ and find out why your friend has such a strange name…”

“All right, since you want to see it,” Duncan shook his head and looked at Shirley with a bit of helplessness. “Let Dog come out and say hello. After all, it’s also today’s ‘guest’.”

Under normal circumstances, Shirley would never expose the secret between herself and Dog. In an orderly city-state, walking together with Abyssal demons was an extreme taboo. If the priests of the Church of the Deep Sea sensed even a trace of the Abyssal Deep’s aura, they could point an Eight-Pound Cannon and a Six-Barrel Machine Gun at her without a second thought.

But now, a Subspace Shadows-level existence was asking her to summon Dog.

“…Okay.”

She nodded, then slowly raised her arm.

In the next second, under Nina’s shocked and slightly nervous gaze, pitch-black flames and thick smoke suddenly rose around Shirley!

Chains stretched out from the flames, and at the end of the smoke and dark fire, the form of a Abyssal demon took shape.

The Abyssal Hound appeared in the flames, then in a single second it shrank into a ball, wrapped its front paws around its head to hide its scariest eye sockets, and, inside a puff of black smoke, greeted Nina in a muffled voice: “Good evening, Miss. I am Dog, Shirley’s friend and guardian dog. My looks do not meet the mainstream human sense of beauty, but you can

view me with an abstract and tolerant eye. That way I am just a clever stack of bone shards and a patch of fire with a slightly unusual color…”

Duncan gave Shirley a calm look: “Honestly, I’ve never seen a dog that acts this much from the heart… Judging by personality alone, it’s actually quite cute.”

On the other side, Nina stared, dumbfounded. She stared at Dog for a long moment before finally letting out a cry: “Ah!”

Shirley hurried to speak: “I told you you might be scared…”

But before she could finish, she heard the second half of Nina’s shout: “This is amazing too!”

Shirley was speechless: “…?”

“Y-you… hello?” While Shirley was still stunned, Nina had already begun to greet Dog, testing the words. “Mr. Dog? Uh, are you a ‘mister’?”

“Abyssal demons have no gender, but if you wish, you may call me that,” Dog answered in a muffled voice, sounding a bit surprised as well. “You… are not afraid of me?”

“It’s not so bad. You do look a little scary, though,” Nina thought for a moment, then broke into a bright smile. “But I’m pretty brave~”

Chapter 126: What Did You See

Watching Nina go from shock and nerves to pure excited curiosity in just a moment, Shirley really could not hold back and muttered under her breath: “At this point, you are way past just being brave…”

Nina did not hear what Shirley was whispering. All of Nina’s attention was already drawn to the pitch-black skeletal hound in front of her. She jumped down from the chair and walked around Dog twice, carefully studying him from head to toe. When she finally saw Dog’s hollow eye sockets, filled with blood-red light, she did get a fright, but it was only a little scare.

“So amazing…” she repeated again. She even looked like she wanted to reach out and touch Dog’s bony head, but at the last second she pulled her hand back. Instead, she lifted her head to look at Shirley: “This is my first time seeing an supernatural being with my own eyes… What is Dog? Is he a creature summoned by a spell, or…”

“He is a demon,” Shirley answered honestly. She sounded as if she wanted to scare Nina, to make Nina realize at least a bit how dangerous Dog was. “The most dangerous kind of demon.”

Nina was indeed a little stunned. She had not expected that this creature who, aside from his ugly appearance, seemed polite in every way would actually carry the name of “demon.” Her face was full of disbelief: “He is… a demon?”

“Strictly speaking, a Abyssal demon,” Dog raised his head a little. His hollow eye sockets turned their gaze on Nina. “Miss, this is probably the

first time you have seen a Abyssal demon. Do not let my existence give you the wrong impression of Abyssal demons. My kin come in many shapes, and what they have in common is that they are especially cruel and merciless…”

“Abyssal Deep…” Nina froze for a moment. She finally woke up from the mix of nervousness and novelty of seeing an supernatural being for the first time, and she recalled what the books had said: “Shirley, you…”

“As you can see, I am bound to Abyssal demons,” Shirley lifted her arm and showed Nina the chain that had fused into her body. “So I do not want people to know my secret. Do you understand? If people from the Deep Sea Church find out, they will throw me into a fire without a second thought, or throw me into the Boundless Sea.”

Shirley’s expression was very serious. From this, Nina realized something. She gave Shirley a slightly complicated look, then looked at Dog again: “… I read in a book that in the Deep Sea within the Abyssal Deep, there are crazed, evil creations everywhere. They are the waste expelled from the holy body of the Abyssal Deep. From birth to their end, they are ruled by chaos and madness. But Mr. Dog looks…”

“Dog is special,” Shirley said quietly. “Normal Abyssal demons have no heart and do not understand human feelings. But Dog does. Even he does not know why this change happened to him. Because of it, he cannot survive in the Deep Sea of the Abyssal Deep anymore.”

Nina stared in a daze, half understanding, and nodded: “Oh.”

While she spoke, she fell into a short silence. Then she suddenly scratched her hair and looked at Duncan with some distress: “Uncle, my head feels all messy.”

She thought back over the chaotic things she had gone through today, the time she had spent with Shirley, and then looked at Dog in front of her. A strange sense of unreality, as if she had stepped outside the Mortal Realm, finally and clumsily rose up inside her.

“You went through a lot today,” Duncan’s gentle and calm voice came, like a candle lighting up in the dark. It made Nina’s suddenly dazed mind settle down again. “Feeling a bit confused is normal.”

Nina blinked and finally realized what she had been ignoring. She looked straight at Duncan: “Uncle, if you already knew Shirley… did you know her secret too? Do you know Dog as well?”

“Earlier than you did,” Duncan showed a faint smile. “But before this, I did not know she was the ‘friend’ you kept talking about.”

“Then…” Nina hesitated for a moment. “Then are you also investigating what happened eleven years ago? Are you two investigating together?”

“More or less. We happened to work together once or twice,” Duncan nodded.

“…Why do I feel like I am the only one you both kept in the dark?” Nina muttered, a little slow on the uptake. “And you are investigating what happened eleven years ago… Was there really some secret in what happened back then?”

“Right now we still do not know. But we both agree that there was a great fire back then that was erased from the records,” Duncan said in a low voice. His eyes fell on Nina. “I am sorry. I did hide it from you, because this is not a field you can deal with right now. It is too dangerous.”

“What about you, Uncle?” Nina suddenly got a little angry. “Uncle, are you not in danger?”

As soon as she said this, Duncan had not even replied yet when Dog and Shirley both covered their faces at the same time. Shirley even muttered softly: “Of course your Uncle is dangerous. Your Uncle is the most dangerous one…”

Duncan gave Shirley a silent look, then turned back to Nina and shook his head lightly: “Your Uncle is an adult. And as for me, I am much stronger than you think.”

Nina’s gaze moved back and forth between Duncan and Shirley. Her expression changed several times. No one knew how many messy thoughts were spinning around in her head. Just when Duncan thought this young lady might get stubborn or start sulking like an ordinary teenage girl, Nina suddenly sighed.

“It is getting dark,” she looked up at the sky outside the door, as if all the things they had just talked about had never happened. “I will go cook. Shirley, you stay too. It is not safe to travel after dark.”

“Ah… ah?” Shirley did not react at first and could not keep up with Nina’s train of thought. Then she quickly waved her hands. “No, no, that is not necessary. If Dog and I hurry back, we can still make it…”

Before she finished, Duncan’s voice came from the side: “Stay here. The Sun will set in a few minutes. When it does, the streets will be full of Guardians. Are you sure you want to cross a locked-down district in that situation?”

Shirley’s whole body stiffened. She turned and glanced at the sky outside the shop, then at Duncan’s calm face. She finally realized that there was no way she was leaving this antique shop today.

“Then… all right,” the girl sat down in defeat. She forced a smile and looked at Nina. “Is there anything I can help with?”

“No need. I always cook at home,” Nina smiled as she walked toward the stairs leading to the second floor. But just as she was about to step onto the first step, she suddenly stopped. She stood there and looked at Shirley very seriously. Only after a few seconds did she speak: “Shirley, are we friends?”

Shirley was stunned. Her first reaction was to glance at Duncan, but Duncan turned his eyes away. She had no choice but to turn back and look at Nina again. After a few seconds of short but painful silence, she shook her head: “…No.”

But right after that, she nodded: “But I can try.”

Nina smiled. Even though the answer was not very certain, she looked as if she had already received the perfect reply. She ran upstairs quickly, her footsteps fast and light.

Shirley stared blankly as Nina ran up to the second floor. Only then did she suddenly hear a calm voice from the side: “Thank you.”

It was Duncan speaking.

Shirley jumped in fright. She quickly sat up straight in her chair and turned to Duncan: “Why are you thanking me?”

“Nina has no friends at school,” Duncan was already used to how tense she always became. He kept his tone mild. “So when she mentioned a few days ago that she had made a new friend at school, she was very happy.”

Shirley blinked in confusion. She had not quite understood.

“So first of all, thank you for not casually telling Nina that you are her friend. And second, thank you because you said you can try.”

“I… do not really understand,” Shirley was still very confused. In fact, she was more confused than before. “Here, you are just playing the role of an ordinary person, right? Nina seems to have no idea how special you are. At

school, too, she has almost no presence. If Dog had not guided me, I almost did not find her the first time I went there. But by normal logic, someone like her, favored by you as a ‘retainer’…”

“Not a retainer. A niece,” Duncan corrected her again. Then, with a very serious expression, he looked at her. “Now that Nina has gone upstairs, I have a question for you.”

“Please, go ahead. Please…”

“It was Dog who guided you to get close to Nina, right?”

“…Yes.”

“Because Dog ‘smelled’ a certain aura on Nina? And from that, he judged that Nina was connected to the fire eleven years ago?”

“Yes.”

“What kind of aura exactly? The same aura as that factory, or something else?”

This time, Shirley did not answer. She turned her eyes to Dog.

Under Duncan’s gaze, Dog hesitated for a few seconds, then finally lowered his head:

“There are ashes floating around her. Countless ashes, Mr. Duncan.”

Chapter 127: Sharing Dinner

Some things were never meant to be discussed in front of Nina.

Hearing the scene that Dog described, Duncan’s heart gave a sudden jolt.

Ashes floating around her… a great many ashes. What did that mean?

In that factory covered by The Veil, hidden ashes lay everywhere. Ashes were the marks left by flame, the proof that a great fire had once existed, and the symbol of things already destroyed. So the ashes around Nina…

He raised his head and looked at the stairs leading to the second floor.

Nina was busy in the kitchen upstairs. From here, he could faintly hear the sounds of her cooking. The clatter of pots and pans sounded light and cheerful. That optimistic girl had been through a lot today, yet she was still in a good mood at this moment.

He drew back his gaze and looked at Shirley, who was sitting across from him.

“So after Dog told you he had found a very suspicious target, you found a way to slip into the school and tried to look for clues around Nina. At the same time, you started approaching the Suntists moving around the city and tried to look for clues from them too, to uncover the secret behind the fire eleven years ago…”

Shirley nodded lightly: “Yes.”

“I am guessing you are actually not looking for a fragment of the Sun, are you?”

“…What would be the point of looking for a fragment of the Sun?” Shirley asked in return. “Find a ball of flame and ask it why it burns? What I want to find… is the person who set the fire back then.”

“This is not an ordinary flame,” Duncan looked calmly into Shirley’s eyes with his gaze. “If that really is a fragment of the Sun, its power is far more than enough to burn down one factory. Shirley, you are doing something very, very dangerous.”

“If I am honest, please do not be mad,” Shirley thought for a moment and lowered her head obediently. “Just sitting in front of you already feels dangerous enough to me…”

“…Ha. Maybe,” Duncan paused for a second, then could not help but laugh. After that, he rose from behind the counter and slowly walked toward the stairs to the second floor. “I was only giving a friendly reminder. How you judge it is up to you.”

“Wait,” Shirley suddenly stood up. She hesitated for two seconds before speaking again. “From how you reacted… you really did not know about Nina’s special side before?”

Duncan stopped and thought for a moment. Then he raised his hand and pointed at his own eyes: “It seems the ‘eyesight’ of this body I am using now is not very good. There are some things I really did not notice.”

This body…

Shirley sharply caught those words, but she did not dare to ask anything. She only watched him as he continued to walk up the stairs, and she could not help asking with some curiosity: “What are you going to do now?”

“Do? I am going upstairs to eat dinner, of course,” Duncan looked down at her as if it were only natural. “You two come up as well. It is dinnertime.”

It was dinnertime.

What did it feel like to eat at the home of a big boss from Subspace?

Shirley had no idea how she should describe all the strange thoughts flashing through her head as she followed that big boss upstairs. She was nervous yet expectant, curious yet afraid. Even though she knew it was very likely just an ordinary everyday meal, she still could not stop guessing what kind of terrifying and bizarre things might appear on the table later.

In this seemingly ordinary antique shop lived a Shadow from Subspace. This was the nest of a Subspace Shadow, the collapsed gap between the Mortal Realm world and the world of the deep layers. In such a nest, even if a spawn of an Eldritch God appeared on the dining table, she would not find it strange at all.

With a mind full of wild guesses and a tense heart, Shirley went upstairs and entered the slightly narrow kitchen. Then she saw what was on the table.

It was only a plate of hard bread that had just been reheated, a pot of vegetable soup that was the most common in the Lower City, and some tomato sauce and mushroom sauce.

The most eye-catching thing on the whole table was just a pot of fish soup. In the pale broth floated a few chunks of fish meat that had already been cut and prepared so that their original shape could no longer be told. A fresh, fragrant smell drifted over and made Shirley’s stomach twist with hunger.

“I used the remaining half of the salted fish in the kitchen to make soup,” Nina said to Duncan with a smile, then looked at Shirley. “Uncle bought this fish. You should try it. It tastes really good.”

Shirley sat down at the table in a bit of a daze. Her eyes swept over the simple dishes. Duncan saw this and could not help but smile: “What is it?

Are the dishes too ordinary, so it surprised you instead? Or do they not suit your taste?”

“No, no… This is already much better than what I usually eat…” Shirley replied at once, then added, “But I really did not expect it to be this ordinary.”

“This fish looks a little strange,” Dog also stretched his head over to look at the food on the table and spoke in his dull, muffled voice. “I feel… a bit of a familiar aura.”

“What do you know about good food?” Shirley glanced at him. “You usually gnaw on stones like they are biscuits…”

“Mr. Dog does not eat food?” Nina looked amazed.

“Abyssal demons do not eat human food. In fact, they do not need to eat at all,” Shirley nodded. “Sometimes they just gnaw on stones or steel plates to grind their teeth.”

Dog’s head shook as he hummed in protest: “That hurts my feelings. Have you forgotten how I tried everything to steal food outside to feed you back then? Sometimes I also eat…”

As he spoke, he lay his front paws on the edge of the table and leaned closer to the pot of fish soup. But after staring at the soup for two seconds, the second half of his sentence cut off sharply.

In the next instant, the Abyssal Hound suddenly yanked his gaze away, slipped back to where he had been lying before, and then slumped down, not moving at all.

Shirley was stunned by his reaction: “Dog, what is wrong with you?”

The first thing Dog did was look at Duncan. What he saw was Duncan’s gentle smile.

“What is it? You do not like fish?” that indescribable vortex of light and shadow asked with a smile.

Dog’s head swayed left and right. All of a sudden, he felt that all the friendly talk, the kind and easy smile, and the sense of working together were nothing but illusions. In the twisted light and shadow deep inside that unspeakable vortex, there was only terror.

A Deep Sea spawn with a rank higher than his had been chopped up and boiled into soup, and even its very nature had truly been turned into “food”… This horrifying thing was happening right there on the table.

“I… do not like fish.”

The Abyssal Hound spoke in a muffled voice.

In the corner of his eye, that freshly cooked fish soup still sent up steaming heat and a smell that was delicious to human noses.

He knew that what was in that pot really was fish now. No matter what it had been before, now it was fish.

The essence of the spawn had long since been twisted and rewritten. Without the eyes granted to him by the Abyssal Lord, even he could never have recognized what those chopped pieces of meat used to be.

Now, it truly was harmless food. Even if Shirley ate it, nothing would happen.

But Dog himself was not going anywhere near that table today, no matter what.

Duncan did not know why Dog suddenly had such a strong reaction to the fish soup. He guessed it had something to do with the special diet of Abyssal demons, so he did not pay it much attention.

His attention was on Nina.

Nina did not look much different from usual. She might have more on her mind now, but this sensible child had chosen a way of handling her feelings that would not put anyone in an awkward spot.

On the other hand, Duncan already knew that something was “hidden” around Nina.

Or to put it another way, that vast and invisible Veil from the factory had silently spread over and settled on Nina too.

He did not dare make a direct judgment yet, and there was no way to be sure what the ashes drifting around Nina really meant. But there was no doubt that during the fire eleven years ago, Nina must have been in an extremely special position.

Just as special as that factory.

Yet Nina knew nothing. She had lived eleven years in complete ignorance.

“Uncle?” Nina finally noticed Duncan’s gaze and looked at him in confusion. “What is wrong?”

Duncan did not answer. He only reached out his hand and gently patted the top of Nina’s head.

Nina froze for a moment, then shook her head from side to side: “I am not a little child anymore.”

“I know, you are not a little child,” Duncan smiled. Between the strands of Nina’s hair that swayed, tiny ghostly green lights flashed for a second and vanished. “But you are still a child.”

Nina puffed out her cheeks a little.

“Uncle, are you going to keep going out with Shirley to… ‘investigate’?”

She finally could not hold back her question.

“Within a safe range,” Duncan answered very seriously.

“…Can you not go?”

Duncan shook his head: “I cannot.”

Nina went quiet for a moment, then asked: “Then what can I do?”

“Eat your dinner properly,” Duncan smiled and pointed at the table. “Then sleep well, study well, protect yourself in the end, and trust your Uncle Duncan.”

Nina stuffed a piece of bread into her mouth until her cheeks were puffed out.

“All right. I got it.”

Chapter 128: Changing Course

The second floor of the antique shop was not very big. Besides the kitchen and the washroom, there were only two rooms, one for Duncan and one for Nina. The temporary guest Shirley obviously could only sleep in Nina's room.

"Actually, I can sleep in the hallway…"

Watching Nina busy getting things ready for her, Shirley looked a little uneasy. "Or I could just make a bed on the floor downstairs…"

"That won't do," Nina said as she spoke, glancing toward the door. Uncle Duncan had already gone back to his own room. Now only she and Shirley were here, plus Dog, who was lying nearby, dozing. "How can we let a guest sleep in the hallway? And downstairs… downstairs is all Uncle's 'treasures'. He would never agree."

"His treasures?" Shirley froze for a moment and tried to recall what she had seen on the first floor. She had been so nervous earlier that she had not even taken a good look at the place, but now that she thought back, the first floor just seemed like a pile of messy junk. To say that this was the collection of a Subspace Shadow was honestly a bit absurd.

But she quickly came back to her senses. Here, that "Mr. Duncan" only played the role of an ordinary person, and the Nina in front of her seemed to truly not know that her Uncle had other faces.

At that thought, Shirley's expression turned strange again. In the bright light from the electric lamp, she quickly glanced at Nina and asked in a low

voice: “Are you really not angry?”

Nina stopped making the bed and raised her eyebrows: “Angry? Why?”

“…I actually lied to you for quite a long time,” Shirley said softly. In her whole life she had rarely been this embarrassed and quiet, but ever since she met “Mr. Duncan”, she was getting more and more used to speaking in a low voice. “At first I only approached you because of Dog’s hint, but I didn’t think you would believe me so easily, or even… just accept me as your ‘friend’ so simply. I think you should be at least a bit angry.”

“…No one had taken the initiative to talk to me at school for a long time. Back then I thought…” Nina muttered, then quickly shook her head. “But I’m really not angry. No matter what the reason was, you really did keep me company, talking, shopping, and going to The City Museum with me.”

Shirley did not really accept Nina’s calm reaction. Or rather, she had long since gotten used to a much colder kind of human relationship, so next to Nina, who seemed to give off a warm glow all the time, she felt especially out of place: “You really are a strange person.”

“Am I?” Nina finished making the bed and sat down, tilting her head a little. “But someone did say that about me a long time ago… ‘This child has such a big heart.’ I think that’s how they said it.”

As she spoke, she waved Shirley over: “Come sit too. Why are you just standing there?”

Shirley froze for a moment, then sat down beside Nina with some hesitation. Her feelings grew even stranger.

She had never imagined things would end up like this.

She was being watched by a Subspace Shadow and had no choice but to take shelter in its “lair”. She was sharing a room with that Subspace Shadow’s “retainer”, and ever since earlier, Dog had curled up into a tight

ball from some nameless fear. She knew how dangerous and strange the true situation was at this moment, maybe only a step away from death. Yet when she opened her eyes, all she actually saw was the warm yellow light of the lamp, and a girl whose smile felt just as warm.

“The electric light is really bright…”

As if she wanted to break the tension, or maybe just could not think of anything else to say, Shirley suddenly muttered in a low voice.

“You don’t have electric lights where you live?” Nina sounded surprised.

“I live in… an older part of town. There aren’t any electric lights there yet,” Shirley said, a little embarrassed. “After nightfall we still have to use oil lamps.”

“Ah…” Nina opened her mouth and felt a little uncomfortable, then forced herself to change the subject. “Do you want to change into pajamas? You can wear mine. I have one from two years ago. It should fit you.”

“…Okay.”

“Let’s go to bed early today. Tomorrow is a rest day. In the morning I’ll walk around with you nearby and, by the way, buy you a new dress. Your skirt was all burned.”

“…I don’t have any money.”

“Then treat it as a gift from me.”

“…Okay.”

…

Duncan stood at the bedroom windowsill and quietly looked toward the Sixth District. His expression grew calm.

The two girls had already fallen asleep in the next room. After everything that happened today, he did not know if Shirley felt tired, but Nina definitely was.

He closed his eyes a little and turned his head to “look” to the side.

In the darkness of his vision, two tiny green flames leaped up.

They were in the direction of the next room. The two flames were Marks he had left. One came from Shirley, and the other showed Nina’s position.

Duncan still did not know what the ashes circling around Nina meant, nor what secrets were really buried in this city-state. He did not know where that “Veil” came from, nor who was pulling the strings behind everything.

But he could feel that he was getting close to the truth from eleven years ago. Bit by bit, he was prying at the thick fog that hung over this city-state, condensed from some kind of supernatural element.

Leaving a mark on Nina was one layer of insurance. This mark let him sense her condition at once and served as a locator in an emergency. And if he later figured out what the “ashes” around Nina were, he could also use the mark’s power to intervene right away, at least isolating Nina from any harmful supernatural forces around her.

But one layer of insurance was not enough.

Duncan looked at his own hands.

This body was still too weak and too far from his true body. The power the true body could send over, and the power this body could handle, were both limited, while the danger hidden in this city-state was likely beyond his expectations.

He took a light breath and slowly closed his eyes.

In the next second, Duncan aboard the Vanished opened his eyes, stood up, and pushed open the door of the captain's cabin.

Goathead's noisy voice came almost without delay: "Oh, great Captain! Your loyal *et cetera* is currently recalibrating…"

"In which direction is the Pland city-state?" Duncan glanced at Goathead and cut him off with skill born of practice.

"Pl… the Pland city-state?!" Goathead was caught off guard. Even his stiff wooden face showed a flash of shock, but he quickly reacted, and his tone turned oddly excited. "The Pland city-state! A human city-state! Is the great Captain Duncan finally going to launch a plundering expedition?! Is this your target? Are we going to attack the Harbor directly, or raid the merchant ships passing by the city-state? We could also slowly corrupt the coastal waters and seal off their shoreline step by step. The City Navy might be a bit of a prob…"

"Shut up. Don't make extra plans," Duncan walked straight to the chart table and knocked on it. "I'm only asking you: which direction is the Pland city-state?"

"Oh, oh, all right, all right, as you wish…"

Goathead's voice dropped and stretched out strangely as he began to speak, and in the next second, Duncan noticed a flickering point of light appear at the edge of the fog-filled enchanted sea chart.

"The Pland city-state you are looking for… should not be too far off," Goathead said respectfully. "Ah, sadly, the enchanted sea chart has slept for too long. It can only mark Pland's general position. The sea conditions and markers along the way are still hidden in the unknown…"

"It looks quite far," Duncan glanced at the bright point in the mist, judged the size of the charted sea around the Vanished, and frowned slightly. "At

full speed, how long will it take us to get close to Pland's coastal waters?"

"Half a month? Maybe a month? That's actually already very fast. We haven't really gone all the way to the edge of civilization yet," Goathead started rambling. "You could also choose to let the Vanished move at full speed in the Spirit Realm, but that wouldn't be very safe. The Spirit Realm itself isn't much of a threat to us, but in the Abyssal Deep Sea, there are many reckless beings who might cause trouble…"

The Abyssal Deep… the Deep Sea…

Duncan subconsciously thought of Dog, but quickly shook his head. "Then let's sail in the Mortal Realm sea for now and move toward the Pland city-state. One last question: can we avoid being discovered by the city-state?"

He fixed his gaze on Goathead's eyes.

As the captain of the Vanished, this question was a little risky.

He was supposed to have complete control over this ship and to fully understand everything it could do.

But he still asked. He was testing this First Mate bit by bit.

Goathead's obsidian-carved eyes showed no emotion. He simply stared back at the captain, and after a few seconds of silence, spoke as usual: "… We can hide in the mist. If needed, we can briefly slip into the broken reflections of the waves. That way, at least when we are more than fifteen nautical miles from shore, human city-states and ships will not be able to sense the Vanished approaching.

"But any closer won't work. A God's gaze will notice, and the city's great Cathedral will raise the alarm."

"All of that is experience from a century ago," Duncan said calmly. "Does it still work now?"

“Of course,” Goathead replied lightly. “A mere century. The Gods would not have made any progress in a single century.”

Duncan let out a small breath. “Very good. Then let the Vanished move toward the Pland city-state and pay attention to hiding itself.”

“May I ask something?” Goathead spoke again. “What… are you planning to do exactly?”

“I just want to run a test,” Duncan thought for a moment, then showed a small smile. “To see if the Wi-Fi is any better this way.”

Goathead froze. “…Wi… what does that mean?”

“I’ll have AI explain it to you later.”

“No! Your loyal *et cetera* has absolutely no interest in what it means!”

Chapter 129: Night

The Vanished picked up to full speed.

In the pale glow cast by the World's Wound, the translucent spirit form sails billowed without wind. The huge, complex forest of masts and ropes creaked as if moved by countless unseen hands, adjusting their angles quickly and precisely. Duncan felt the hull under his feet sway and tilt, the bow turning toward some direction in the Boundless Sea. The fine sound of waves slapping against the hull mixed with the "sensory signals" that the Vanished itself sent back, echoing softly in the depths of his mind.

For some reason, the moment the ship changed course, he suddenly felt that the mood on the ship had quietly changed. The scenery around was clearly exactly the same, but…

It felt as if he heard the ship let out a quiet sigh of satisfaction.

Duncan left the captain's cabin and strolled onto the deck. In the night, he raised his head and cast his gaze at the swollen sails and towering masts, then reached out and tapped a nearby railing, saying thoughtfully: "Are you also bored with drifting around without a goal?"

The Vanished did not answer. Only a faint creaking rose from beneath the deck. Several ropes nearby rustled, sliding over like snakes and swaying back and forth beside Duncan.

"…That is not cute. It's actually a bit scary," Duncan gave the ropes a look. "This is how you scared Alice into running for her life last time, isn't it?"

The ropes swayed in place twice, then slipped away quickly.

Duncan took a light breath, ready to enjoy the cool night wind at sea. But suddenly, a distant “tug” appeared in his consciousness.

At first he did not react to what it was, but then he realized that the tug came from the Pland city-state.

In the Pland city-state, Duncan on the second floor of the antique shop suddenly blinked and immediately looked in a certain direction. That was Nina’s room next door.

In his sight, a cluster of ghostly emerald flame was flickering rapidly in that room. It was not Nina, but the mark left on Shirley.

That flame had sensed supernatural power growing and sensed that its host’s emotions were fluctuating abnormally.

What happened to Shirley?!

Duncan did not hesitate. He got up, rushed out of his room, and came to the door of Nina’s bedroom. He knocked lightly, but there was no response inside.

He hesitated for a moment, but in the next second he felt the mark on Shirley flicker again.

There was no time to overthink at a moment like this. Duncan pushed open Nina’s door.

Just like when she was little, Nina still did not have the habit of locking her door when she slept.

The bedroom was dim. Only the faint light of the streetlamp outside shone in through the window, outlining the shapes of things in the room. Within his field of view, Duncan did not see anything out of the ordinary.

Shirley and Nina were quietly sleeping on the bed. One had her head toward the foot of the bed, and the other lay sideways across the other's stomach.

…Their sleeping positions were very artistic.

Of course, Duncan had no interest in studying how the two girls slept. He had already noticed the deep frown on Shirley's face, and on the arm she normally used to summon Dog and form the symbiotic pact with the chains, faint black lines were slowly crawling.

Duncan frowned slightly, then activated the mark he had left on Shirley, trying to use the special nature of the spirit form flame to search for the source of "corruption" in the room.

In his view, Shirley's current state, together with the mark's warning, was without a doubt a sign that supernatural power was starting to produce corruption.

A tiny green flame rose up beside Shirley. The ghostly green fire lit the surroundings, but after flickering a few times, it stayed right where it was.

There was no corruption in the room.

Duncan's brow furrowed. He leaned closer and studied the tight frown on Shirley's face.

Because he did not know how much the spirit form fire might affect living people, he could not release a large mass of flames to "scan" the whole room the way he had in the factory. But even a single spark of spirit form fire should react to unfamiliar supernatural power.

corruption… was not in the Mortal Realm? On the mental level? Or was it something else?

Duncan fell into thought. Then he seemed to think of something, quietly left the room, and closed the door. Back in his own bedroom, he saw the Pigeon Spirit dozing on the windowsill.

“Spirit Realm Walk.”

Amid AI’s angry cooing after being woken, Duncan once more entered that dark space filled with endless starlight. Then he calmed himself, and like when he had sensed the White Oak and Vanna before, he focused on the starlight around him that belonged to his own Marks.

This was not hard, because those Marks had been left on purpose by him and were much clearer and more stable than the “sparks” on Vanna. Duncan almost instantly locked onto the point of starlight that belonged to Shirley…

Shirley opened her eyes in the dark and found herself lying on a small bed that was both familiar and strange.

Feeling her way in the dark, she sat up. Her mind stayed sluggish for a long while before she slowly woke. She looked around in confusion and finally made out some outlines in the darkness.

Some familiar yet distant memories slowly woke up. After she saw the scene around her clearly, Shirley’s eyes flew wide open.

In the next second, she jumped down from the bed, letting out a string of furious curses, so furious that her voice even trembled, the tremble carrying fear and panic: “Damn, damn, damn… damn it! It’s this again, this again! Damn it!”

The loud stream of curses shattered the quiet in the dark, but the voice was not the one Shirley was used to. It was younger, more childish, a child’s voice that had only existed in her memories. She landed on the floor and saw that her hands and feet had become as thin and small as they were in

those memories. She wore a light pink nightgown, exactly the same as in her memory, with the familiar little dog clumsily stitched over the torn cuff.

“Stop messing with me! Stop messing with me!”

Shirley shouted in the dark room and rushed to the closed door. She kicked and punched, trying to break the mottled wooden boards, but the door was as unmoving as if cast from steel and concrete. She threw her head against it, even bit the doorknob, but it was all just a meaningless way to vent. With her small body she could only slam into it again and again, while the Time-Stream flowed past, while a little morning light crept in through the nearby window, while the sound she least wanted to hear on this early morning came from outside the door.

She heard someone get up in the next room. She heard footsteps, and the sounds of things being packed.

She heard one set of footsteps approach the door, and a very gentle, very familiar voice spoke softly: “Shirley, Shirley? Are you up? Are you still angry?”

Shirley’s pounding stopped all at once, as if all strength had been drained from her. She leaned against the wooden door, pressing herself to it with everything she had. She did not want to listen, yet greedily took in every sound from outside.

“Shirley, Dad and I are going to buy you a cake. Today is your birthday… When we come back, you won’t be angry anymore, all right?”

“Don’t go…” Shirley suddenly spoke. At first it was just a tiny mutter, but soon the mutter turned into a shout. “Don’t go… Don’t go! Don’t go! Don’t go!”

At last she cried out, shouting even though she knew it was useless: “Don’t go! Don’t go out! Don’t go out, damn it! Don’t go out!”

But time still moved on to the next second, like a memory carved into her mind that could never go back. The footsteps outside the door went farther away.

The sound of a bag being picked up, her parents' distant, blurry conversation, the turn of the doorknob, opening, closing, and the key turning once, then half a turn more.

Shirley slowly sat down in the dark and began to count her own heartbeat.

When she reached the one thousand two hundredth beat, shouts of "Fire!" came from far away.

When she reached the one thousand six hundredth, the stinging smell of smoke and choking fumes began to seep through the crack under the door.

When she counted to one thousand eight hundred, the street outside was full of frantic shouting, and harsh red light flooded the window, as if the whole city-state had been dropped into molten lava.

When she reached the two thousandth heartbeat, a heavy dull crash came from the front door. The door had been broken, as if some huge beast was stepping in with heavy footsteps, coming closer step by step to this locked room.

Then the door of the room finally fell. The wooden door that Shirley could not have broken even with all her strength shattered like torn paper.

A terrifying creature appeared there. It was a huge black Hellhound, a nightmare twisted together from bone, shadows, smoke, and burning ash. For a six-year-old child, this demon from the Abyssal Deep was almost a giant. Now its empty, blood-red sockets had already locked onto the "living thing" in the room.

Shirley calmly fixed her gaze on the Hellhound in front of her.

This was a Abyssal Hound, but it was not yet her Dog.

It was not the Dog who had a “heart”, not the Dog who rummaged through trash bins to find food for her, not the Dog who tried to tell bad jokes to make her laugh and ended up only teaching her a pile of swear words.

The Abyssal Hound stepped into the room.

The sound of flesh and bone being chewed rang out.

Shirley lay on the floor, feeling her limbs being devoured by the Hellhound. The piercing pain was muffled and numb as it spread through her mind through the Veil of eleven years of memory. She kept counting her own heartbeat, counting how long until Dog would become her Dog, and calculating how long she would have to stay here this time. Based on past experience, would it be a week? Or two weeks?

Her consciousness slowly started to blur. Even in this pitch-black dream, the distant, dull, and numb pain finally began to catch up with her. In her ever more vague vision, she suddenly saw a figure appear on the bed not far away, in the deepest darkness of the shadows.

The figure did not seem to have appeared all of a sudden. It was as if he had been there from the very beginning, from the start of this dream, from the start of every dream, and even—Shirley did not know why she would have such a shocking thought—even from eleven years ago.

He just sat there, yet she only noticed his existence for the first time now, as if a long-standing fog had suddenly split open, letting her glimpse what lay behind it.

A faint glimmer of ghostly green flame emerged from nowhere, lighting up the figure’s face: gloomy and imposing. Shirley had never seen this face before, yet she felt a strange familiarity.

“No offense meant.”

The gloomy, imposing figure spoke.

Chapter 130: Your Fearsome Name Is Known to All

“No offense meant.”

The figure spoke. Almost the instant he spoke, Shirley suddenly heard a booming sound from nowhere. It was an unreal roar. It did not belong to this dream, nor to this memory. It exploded right inside her skull, and as it boomed, the distant crackle of flames and the frantic shouts of the crowd vanished at once.

The whole world fell into absolute silence.

The next second, Shirley realized her body had changed. She was back to being seventeen. She was no longer wearing the familiar nightgown from her memory, but her usual black dress. The arm that the Abyssal Hound had devoured was somehow whole again. A pitch?black chain stretched out from that arm. At the far end of the chain, Dog lay curled in the corner of the room as if asleep, quietly sprawled there, the bloody glow in its eye sockets flickering faintly.

Shirley jolted upright and stared, shocked and tense, at the figure sitting on the bed.

She did not know who this figure was, but she knew one thing: some powerful being had broken straight through the curse of the Abyssal Deep and invaded her dream.

Even she, the “master of this dream”, had not sensed him ahead of time. That meant the intruder was so powerful that she had no way to resist him at all.

“Y-you… who are you?!”

Duncan slowly stood up. In this realm of consciousness, he appeared in his original form as “Captain Duncan”. His towering height pressed down on the room, and Shirley instinctively backed up half a step.

“You have never seen me like this. That reaction is normal,” Duncan said in a low voice. “I noticed you were having a nightmare, so I came to take a look.”

“Noticed… came to take a look…” Shirley blinked in confusion, then slowly came back to herself. “Wait, you are…”

“Let me introduce myself properly. I am Duncan,” the gloomy, imposing man said with a small smile. “Duncan Abnomar.”

He spoke his real name because he was not worried that Shirley would dare spread this around. Even if she did lose her head, that very sensible Abyssal Hound would make sure she kept the matter buried in her heart forever.

“Duncan… Mr. Duncan? You’re Mr. Duncan?!” Shirley stared, eyes wide in shock. A faint, panicked throb spread through her heart. But then confusion followed. “But… aren’t you called Duncan Strain? What is ‘Abnomar’?”

Duncan was silent for a moment: “…?”

This young lady’s reaction left him at a loss. He stared at her for two seconds before finally speaking, his expression odd: “You… have never heard that name?”

Shirley thought for a moment, then shook her head honestly. “No.”

Then she suddenly realized something and looked frightened. “I… should have heard that name?”

Duncan suddenly realized this girl really had never heard the title of the “moving calamity of the Boundless Sea”. Her reaction could not be faked. It seemed that no matter how fearsome Captain Duncan’s reputation was, there were always some people whose knowledge was just that limited. The thought left him a bit deflated, and he could not help asking: “…Are you illiterate?”

To his surprise, Shirley actually lowered her head and said nothing.

“Forget it. It’s not important,” Duncan said. Seeing her reaction, he ended the topic at once. His gaze slowly swept over the small room. Outside, the noise of streets and the sea of fire had already faded, as if a farce had been cut off halfway. Only a dim, dark?red glow still spread beyond the window. Duncan’s eyes came back to Shirley. His face was calm. “This is something you went through back then, isn’t it?”

Shirley still kept her head lowered. “…Mm.”

“…I did not come here to pry, but I sensed your secret while I was entering this place,” Duncan said, very sincere. “I’m sorry.”

Shirley froze. She had never imagined that a being as terrifying as an Eldritch God would apologize to her. The chaos in her head tightened into waves of cold sweat. She hurriedly stumbled back two steps. “N-no, it’s fine. How could you apologize to me…”

“Whatever the case, peeking into a lady’s dreams is not polite—even when it’s a ‘little’ lady like you,” Duncan said with a faint smile. Then his gaze fell on the Abyssal Hound. “When will it wake up?”

“I don’t know…” Shirley looked a little lost. She looked at Dog, still sleeping. “This nightmare has never changed like this before, I—”

She had only said half the sentence when she heard a faint clatter of bones from inside Dog. The hound, fast asleep a second before, gave a small shake of its head. The red light in its hollow eye sockets brightened, and the next moment the terrifying giant hound suddenly leaped to its feet.

Maybe the nightmare from just now still affected her. Shirley instinctively stepped back half a pace. But she quickly came to her senses and walked over to Dog.

“Shirley…” Dog finally woke up. It suddenly noticed the room around them. A second later, its gaze fell sharply on Shirley’s arm. There was a hint of panic in its voice. “I…”

“It’s fine. Just a nightmare,” Shirley said with a smile. She stepped forward and hugged Dog’s huge, ugly skull. “You had a nightmare too.”

“I’m sorry, I’m sorry…” Dog kept whispering the words. The chain linking it and Shirley clinked softly. “Does it hurt? Does it hurt a lot…”

Shirley turned her head aside, a little embarrassed. “Don’t be so dramatic… Someone else is watching…”

“Someone else?” Dog froze for a moment. Only then did it notice there was another person in the room. It saw Duncan clearly, saw the captain’s uniform on him and that gloomy, severe face. More importantly, in its sight it could also see layer upon layer of eerie green flames floating behind Duncan.

“Holy—!” Dog let out a shocked cry. The next second, it reflexively yanked Shirley behind it and used its huge body as a shield between her and Duncan. All the bones across its body rattled and shook, but it still forced itself to stare in Duncan’s direction. “I-it’s the ghost captain?!”

Seeing this reaction, Duncan raised an eyebrow. “Shirley doesn’t recognize this form of mine, but you do?”

“Dog?” Shirley reacted as well. “Dog, you’ve seen him before?”

“Do I even need to? Any Abyssal demon that has seen him has basically already been sent into Subspace by now!” The black smoke inside Dog’s body swelled and sank in panic. “The moving calamity of the Boundless Sea… Why is he in your dream?!”

“The moving calamity of the Boundless Sea?” Shirley was still lost. “Why have I never heard you mention that…”

“Of course you haven’t! There are tons of things I haven’t told you—there are plenty of Calamities in this world. How could I tell you about every single one? And under normal circumstances, who would ever think you’d run into a ghost captain on land?!”

Shirley listened, dazed. She seemed as if she still wanted to ask something, but Duncan suddenly broke the silence. He quietly fixed his gaze on the Abyssal Hound that was acting like it was facing its greatest enemy. “I always thought only people in the Mortal Realm were this afraid of me. I did not expect to have this kind of reputation among Abyssal demons as well.”

Dog edged back half a step, keeping a fully defensive stance as it spoke. “You’re underestimating yourself. Your fearsome name is known from the Deep Sea of the Abyssal Deep all the way to the Mortal Realm. Even heartless Abyssal demons know, by instinct alone, to avoid your Vanished… Honestly, it’s only because Abyssal demons don’t have hearts. Otherwise, even the dreadfiends that crawl over the ashen wasteland would be tattooing you on their backs for courage…”

Duncan thought about it and suspected the creature was actually trying to flatter him—in the way it thought of as flattery.

At the same time, Shirley also heard Dog muttering in a low voice—but the muttering came only through the mental link formed by the chain, and only she could hear it. “Shirley, in a bit I’ll find a way to hold this shadow off. You try your best to wake up. The other side should be only a Psychic Projection. I can tie him up for a while. As long as you can get out of this dream, he won’t be able to chase you…”

Shirley did not react at first—or rather, her thoughts were not on the same wavelength as Dog’s at all. “Uh… and then what?”

Dog’s tone grew urgent. “Then you hurry to the next room and ask that Big Shot for help—tell him you’re being hounded by the Vanished. Be sincere. You can even volunteer to become his retainer in exchange for protection. At this point we can’t worry about whether it’s dangerous or not. Compared to being torn apart by the Vanished and dragged into Subspace, becoming the retainer of some Subspace Eldritch God at least barely counts as ‘alive’…”

Shirley did not react at all.

“Shirley?” Dog grew even more anxious. “Shirley, don’t zone out! Take advantage of the disturbance in this dream and find a way to wake up! Getting a big boss to deal with a big boss is our only—”

Before Dog could finish, Shirley finally answered him through the mental link:

“Dog… Those two big bosses you’re talking about sound like the same person…”

Dog was stunned: “…?”

The exchange in the mental link took only an instant.

The Abyssal Hound lifted its head, looking a little dazed.

In its sight, the ghost captain who commanded the fire of spirit form simply watched them quietly and showed a smile as cold and dark as Subspace.

Chapter 131: Breaking Free of the Dream

Duncan looked at the jumpy Dog and put on the gentlest smile he could manage. He felt there was probably some misunderstanding between them, and it would be best to clear it up sooner rather than later.

But just as he was about to speak, he suddenly saw the bloody light in Dog's eye sockets flicker. Even though you could not read expressions on a skull, he could still somehow feel the Abyssal Hound's emotions surge violently for a moment.

The next second, he heard Dog's stammering voice. "Y-you're the 'Mr. Duncan' we've been dealing with these past two days?"

Duncan paused, then glanced at Shirley beside him.

He did not see any obvious exchange between Dog and Shirley, but it was clear that the two beings linked by the chain had a very convenient way to share information.

"That's me," Duncan said with a small smile and a gentle tone. "Do I still need to explain anything? Or is there something you want to know?"

"Nothing!" Dog almost shrieked, backing away with its whole body. "We don't need to know any 'knowledge' or 'Truth'. We have absolutely no desire to pry into your mysteries!"

"…I keep feeling there's some misunderstanding between us, but somehow the more I try to explain, the less sense it will make," Duncan sighed and

shook his head helplessly. “Forget it. Let time slowly help us build some trust. For now, there are a few things I want to know.”

Dog drooped its skull. “P-please, go ahead.”

Duncan frowned slightly. He was actually quite curious why he, a ghost captain with a fearsome name in the Mortal Realm, had such a huge impact among Abyssal demons as well. In his impression, the Deep Sea of the Abyssal Deep was a “place” especially close to Subspace. The demons that lurked in the deeper layers of the Abyssal Deep should be closer to those “bottom?layer Shadows” than mortals in the Mortal Realm were. In theory, they should not be so fearful and resistant toward the Vanished that returned from Subspace.

Yet now it seemed that those demons, who were already “dangerous beings” from a human point of view, were just as afraid of the Vanished as humans were. That puzzled him a lot.

But before he could get to the bottom of that, his attention went back to the nightmare right in front of him. It came from the depths of Shirley’s memory and very likely replayed the truth from eleven years ago.

“I want to know more about this dream,” he said, turning his gaze to Shirley. “I know it is a very painful memory for you. If you don’t want to talk about it, you can refuse.”

“…There’s nothing I don’t want to say,” Shirley only shook her head lightly. “I should be thanking you. You broke the nightmare and spared me some suffering… What you saw is just what I went through back then.”

“A great fire…” Duncan nodded slightly, then looked toward Dog. “What I saw was how you and Shirley first ‘met’, wasn’t it?”

Dog turned its skull aside. “At the time I was just a Abyssal demon.”

“Then how did you suddenly gain a ‘heart’?” Duncan asked curiously. “From what I just saw, you had almost killed Shirley back then.”

“…I don’t know,” Dog said after a few seconds of silence. Its ugly skull swayed a little. “When I first became self?aware, what I saw was already Shirley lying on the ground, barely breathing.”

Duncan gave the Abyssal Hound a long look. His gaze then followed the chain at its neck and came to Shirley’s body, half of which was black and twisted, fused with the chain in a symbiotic pact.

“And after that, you two… merged together?”

“More or less,” Shirley said in a low voice. She hung her head so that her eyes and expression were hidden in the Shadows of her hair. “Honestly, I don’t remember it that well. I was only six then, and for a long time after that I lived in a daze… If you really want to know how I slowly went from being almost killed by a Abyssal demon to having this kind of relationship with it, you can grab a psychiatrist and have them hypnotize me. Maybe then…”

“No need.”

Shirley’s words were suddenly cut off. Right after that, she felt a large hand press down on the top of her head, to her surprise.

The hand was actually warm.

“Sorry. I didn’t mean to tear open your wounds. I only want to know the details from eleven years ago,” Duncan said softly as he pressed down on the girl’s hair. He knew his questions were not pleasant for Shirley, who had just escaped a nightmare. “You should know that, in the incident eleven years ago, it wasn’t only the shard of the Sun that appeared. Countless cultists were moving in the shadows as well. And a Abyssal Hound… in

theory, it should have been a summoned creature of the Cult of Annihilation.”

Shirley raised her head slightly, still a bit blank. She heard Duncan continue: “A demon?type creature from the Deep Sea of the Abyssal Deep suddenly gaining humanity is, in itself, a kind of ‘mutation’. Have you ever thought that this mutation might also have been triggered by something during that incident?”

Shirley blinked and said a bit slowly, “The shard of the Sun?”

“I’m not sure… No one knows what form the shard of the Sun really takes, or what power it truly has. But in the doctrine spread by the Suntists, the ‘true Sun god’ doesn’t have any divine authority like ‘granting humanity’ or anything similar,” Duncan said, shaking his head. “So whatever gave Dog humanity might be something other than the shard of the Sun… something else that was there.”

“You mean, what appeared in the city?state of Pland eleven years ago might not have been only the shard of the Sun?!” Shirley finally caught up. Her eyes flew wide open.

“It’s only a suspicion,” Duncan said. He patted Shirley’s shoulder lightly and then drew back his hand. “I’ve always felt there is something very off about the whole matter. The shard of the Sun is a ‘sacred relic’ that points to the cult of the Sun. According to those cultists, its power is actually quite simple and, in occult studies, only tied to the ‘true Sun god’. Yet in that chaos eleven years ago, even in the files the authorities made public, the cultists they caught already included Annihilators and Enders—people who had nothing to do with the ‘true Sun god’ at all… What were they doing mixed into it?

“Of course, you could explain it by saying that the shard of the Sun was so powerful that even people who did not believe in the Sun god were affected,

so they all went mad on the same day. But that still can’t explain something as strange as Dog… ‘appearing’—a demon whose very nature is madness suddenly gaining sanity in the middle of the incident. How does that make sense?

“And if you push it further, there are many other suspicious points, including but not limited to the Veil that covered the ‘fire’, the fragments of memory left in your mind and in Nina’s, and the strange phenomena in the Sixth District… We have always lumped all of those oddities together and blamed them on the shard of the Sun. But now that I think about it carefully, are all of them really within ‘the Sun’s domain’ of power? If so, this so? called true Sun god would be a little too omnipotent.”

Duncan spoke the doubts in his heart. Some of them had already arisen long before today. It was only after seeing Dog’s mutation from eleven years ago that he became even more certain of his suspicion.

The great fire eleven years ago might indeed have been caused by the shard of the Sun. But in that whole incident, there had absolutely been something else at work as well!

Shirley was still a bit dazed. She was not good at thinking about things this complicated. While she stared blankly, she heard Dog’s voice ring urgently in her mind. “Shirley, are you okay? When he touched your head just now, was he releasing the curse? Are you still clear?headed? Are you…”

“I’m fine,” Shirley replied in her mind, half amused and half helpless. “Dog, you’re way too nervous.”

“Of course I’m nervous! How could I not be? You just made direct contact with a source of corruption strong enough to drive an ordinary person insane on the spot!” Dog sounded as panicked as could be. “So what do you feel?”

Shirley thought for a moment and uncertainly touched the top of her head.

In her memory, the last time someone had stroked her hair like that and gently comforted her as if she were a small child had been many, many years ago.

“…Warm.”

She spoke in a soft, dazed voice.

Dog was startled at once. “Shirley, has your brain really gone wrong?”

“…Shut up!”

Duncan, however, had no idea what Dog and Shirley had just exchanged in that brief instant. He only stared thoughtfully at the window, where dim red light still spread, and suddenly asked, “What’s outside?”

Shirley was stunned. “Huh?”

Duncan lifted a hand and pointed at the window. “Outside this room. What is there?”

“I… don’t know,” Shirley said, blinking. She suddenly realized that, in this nightmare that had haunted her again and again, something impossible had appeared. “I’ve never thought about that. Every time I dream, I’m trapped in this room…”

“But you’ve broken free now,” Duncan said. He walked to the door of the small room and turned back, speaking softly. His words were like a lure in the dark, throwing an entirely new choice in front of Shirley and Dog. “Do you want to try, while you’re awake… to go see what the edge of your dream looks like?”

Chapter 132: Edge of the Dream

Duncan said with a gentle smile: “Do you want to see, while awake, what the edge of your own dream looks like?”

To Shirley, the words Duncan spoke with a smile sounded like a deep temptation rising from a dark, bottomless sea trench. A shiver spread in her heart. She instinctively resisted this suggestion, yet an uncontrollable urge also rose——

In this nightmare that had tormented her for eleven years, outside this locked little room, on that street she had never seen with her own eyes eleven years ago… what was out there?

She subconsciously took a small breath and turned to look at the small window not far away.

A dull, dried-blood shade of deep crimson filled the little window, so she could not see the street outside. On that fire-lit morning eleven years ago, she had never managed to look out of the window, so in this dream the scene outside was hidden in chaotic light, impossible to make out. Even the living room outside this room was only a blur of darkness when she looked through the doorway.

The dream reflected her own memories and understanding. Eleven years ago she had not escaped this little room. Eleven years later, could she really walk out of it now?

Shirley could not help muttering under her breath: “Can someone really walk around inside their own dream… I don’t even know what’s out there

at all… What if it’s all just nothing?”

Duncan’s voice came from the doorway: “A dream is a reflection of a person’s subconscious, and the subconscious often keeps ‘details’ that even the person cannot notice.” He paused, then said: “Maybe you were trapped in this room the whole time eleven years ago, but the light and shadows outside the window, the sounds, and the things your ‘instinct’ remembered have all filled in your dream. In those details, we might be able to glimpse a few clues.”

“Of course, it’s your decision. If you refuse, I won’t keep prying into your dream—I will stay here. Don’t worry, as long as I am here, this nightmare won’t go on. Sleep in peace. Tomorrow you will still have a clear, sunny morning.”

Shirley bit her lip lightly. It was as if she had to use a lot of strength just to make up her mind: “I… want to go out and take a look.”

“All right.” Duncan nodded and stepped aside to clear the doorway. “I’ll go with you.”

A Subspace Shadow, a moving calamity, had taken the initiative to say he would walk with her—this should have been a terrifying invitation, yet for some reason, this time Shirley suddenly felt relieved.

It was as if a warm light suddenly appeared in this endless dark nightmare, letting her relax just a little.

She felt she had to be insane, slowly stained by madness from living alongside an Eldritch God.

Duncan followed behind Shirley. The two of them stepped together through the wooden door of the little room and entered the living room from Shirley’s childhood memories.

Dog walked beside them as well. The Abyssal Hound looked very tense, always watching the surroundings with care. From time to time it tilted its head as if listening, paying attention to any sign of an Anomaly on the street.

Seeing this, Shirley grew curious: “Dog, what are you doing?”

Dog said in a deep voice: “Reconnaissance. We’re walking into an unknown region of a dreamwalking field… Any further, and it will be an area that doesn’t exist in your memories. In theory, the things ahead will lean more and more toward the imagination and strong emotions in your subconscious, and when fear is the main force, those imaginations and strong emotions often create some… not very friendly things.”

Shirley was surprised: “Dog, you even know that much?”

“I know a little.” Dog shook its head. “I am, after all, a proper Abyssal demon…”

Duncan did not pay attention to Shirley and Dog’s conversation. He was carefully watching the living room for any clues.

A hazy, chaotic darkness covered the small, shabby room, as if some smoke that could not be dispersed filled the air. He saw a wooden shelf by the wall, a table and chairs on one side of the living room, and an old chronometer clock hanging on the wall. The hands on its face were blurred and twisted like trembling smoke, spinning in circles without any meaning.

On the floor in the middle of the living room, he could see a patch of deep claw marks.

Those were the marks Dog had left when it broke in back then.

Other than that, there were no bloodstains in the living room, no corpses, and no trace of fire. The “fire” seemed limited to the street outside, or

maybe, simply in Shirley’s subconscious, the flames had never spread into the room.

They crossed the living room and came to the front door.

The door had a huge hole smashed in it. Only the frame remained, with a few broken pieces of wood still hanging there. It was clearly another masterpiece of the Abyssal Hound.

Beyond it lay the street that had been swallowed by the fire.

Shirley suddenly stopped walking.

She had already come this far, yet all at once she realized what she was truly afraid of and resisting.

“Shirley?” Dog noticed her hesitation and looked up at her in curiosity.

Shirley bit down hard on her lip as if she had not heard Dog. She stared fixedly at the street outside the door, at the thin fog filled with warped red light. Every cell in her body, every nerve, seemed to tighten, shrink back, and tremble with fear.

It was as if she saw her parents, who had gone out that day and never come back, lying fallen in front of the house. She did not even dare to picture what that scene would look like, did not dare imagine what would happen the moment she stepped out.

Then she heard the soft clink of chains.

Dog took the lead and walked forward, stretched its head to look toward the street, then pulled back.

“Shirley, it’s fine. There’s nothing scary outside. Even if there is… you can’t see it anymore.”

Shirley looked in some surprise at the Abyssal Hound's empty eye sockets. She pressed her lips together: "Thanks."

Then she took a step forward and walked out of the doorway of her home from eleven years ago.

The street was filled with a thin mist. In the sparse, dark-red fog she could vaguely make out the outlines of houses and streetlamps, and the warped, uneven surface of the road.

Buildings in the distance shook unnaturally in the fog. The fire had already burned them down to bare frames, black or dark red in color. Their edges trembled like formless flames, and from somewhere came the crackle and pop of exploding timbers, as if the blaze was still spreading in places they could not see.

Fine sparks, dust, and ash floated in the air, mixed with a choking smell.

Duncan frowned slightly.

The flames on the street had died out. Only the traces of burning remained. The ash everywhere and the suspicious melted heaps in the corners of the street proved that the great fire had been real.

But he did not see any clues that might be related to fragments of the Sun.

But when he thought again, that also seemed normal. After all, this was only Shirley's dream, a stage woven together from her memories, understanding, and imagination, not a true restoration of everything as it had been eleven years ago.

With that thought, he walked slowly beside Shirley along the street that had been burned by the fire.

Suddenly, his steps stopped.

Shirley turned back in surprise: "Mr. Duncan?"

Duncan frowned and waved his hand lightly, tilting his head to listen to the sounds around them.

Just now, it seemed he had heard a faint voice whisper something by his ear.

He tried to make it out for a long moment, then suddenly walked toward a pile of ash by the roadside.

It was a twisted heap of black ash, with some charred fragments mixed in that seemed not entirely burned. Next to the ash a few embers still glowed. If one looked very carefully, one could just barely see that the heap of ash faintly formed the shape of a curled-up… “person”.

Duncan stared at the ash for a long time, then slowly bent down and tilted his head, performing a Listening Rite——

“…I… don’t want to die…”

The heap of ash whispered softly.

Duncan’s eyes opened a little wider.

And Shirley, who was close behind him, also heard the whisper. The girl’s reaction was much more direct:

“What the hell is this?!”

Duncan glanced back at her, and Shirley quickly changed her wording: “Uh, I mean, this is really scary…”

“…I still liked your straightforward version better just now.” Duncan’s mouth twitched. In truth, the whisper from the ash had startled him too, but Shirley’s shout had completely covered that. Then his gaze fell on the many other heaps of ash along the street.

Soft, continuous, overlapping whispers drifted with the floating ash and sparks down the street, reaching his and Shirley’s ears.

“I don’t want to die…” “Help…” “…Go home…” “Somebody help…”

A chilling feeling spread from deep in the heart. Shirley moved closer to Dog without thinking, feeling every muscle in her body tighten.

She dared to swing a demon hound around to fight cultists, but she had little resistance against this kind of pure eerie strangeness.

Besides, this was still her own nightmare. The hardest thing for a person to fight is always the fear in their own heart.

But just then, she suddenly felt confused:

[Is this really my nightmare?]

[Is this really just a dream? At this “edge of the dream” that had already gone far beyond my memories and understanding, why would these “voices calling for help” appear, voices I should never have touched or even been able to imagine?]

Shirley instinctively looked toward Duncan, only to see him also turning his gaze. His deep eyes were full of scrutiny and thought.

“This might not be a simple dream.”

Duncan said in a low voice.

Chapter 133: Eerie Shadow

To be fair, Duncan was not any kind of expert in the supernatural field, and he knew little about disciplines related to dreams and the mind. But he could still vaguely judge that the scene on this street was not only what Shirley had “seen in her dream”.

Because those whispering, pleading ashes gave him a strange sense of déjà vu——

He thought of that factory, of the people there who had been burned to ash in the fire and hidden by the Veil.

Of course, the ashes in the factory had not asked him for help. Those ashes had given him a more direct and violent sign, letting him see the “echo” of the great fire eleven years ago with his own eyes.

Instinctively, Duncan felt that the ashes on this street in Shirley’s dream had some connection to the ashes in that factory.

He lifted his head and looked around. In the wavering, dim red light, the whole street showed the ruin left by the great fire. Amid the falling sparks and dust were countless piles of ash, and suspicious black shapes printed on the nearby walls.

He spoke: “Back then you were only six years old. No matter how much your subconscious may have noticed, it should not be enough to support such a huge dream world—and to create all these embers that call for help, and such large areas of phantom images in the distance on top of that.”

Duncan said quietly, and his voice suddenly made the tense and uneasy Shirley feel a little steadier.

Shirley raised her head and looked at Duncan standing beside her. The “Mr. Duncan” here did not look like the one she usually saw. Here he appeared as a gloomy and dignified captain. To be honest, he still looked pretty frightening like this. Even without Dog’s kind of “true sight”, she could feel a deep pressure coming off him.

But in this nightmare that was becoming more and more unfamiliar, such a powerful being still gave her a bit of comfort. At least for now, this being was standing on her side.

“Let’s keep going and see how far the reach of this dream goes.”

Duncan’s voice suddenly came from beside her. Shirley froze for a second, then quickly grabbed Dog and hurried to follow him.

Amid the endless faint whispers of plea coming from the piles of ash, the two people and one hound walked through the street covered in embers and sparks, slowly heading toward the cluster of buildings that twisted and shook in the shadows.

They walked along the street for who knew how long. Duncan kept carefully watching for changes in the scenery along the way, and what made him feel strange was that the view on this street remained the same as before.

No more twisted phantoms appeared. Things did not grow more blurred or bizarre, nor did any of the “dangerous dream creatures” Dog had described show up.

Duncan suddenly stopped, his brows slightly furrowed.

“Mr. Duncan?” Shirley looked at him curiously. “Did you find something again?”

“…How far have we already gone from the ‘origin’?” Duncan lifted his head and looked back in the direction he and Shirley had come from. The house they had set out from was already gone, swallowed by the hazy red mist.

“‘Origin’?” Shirley was stunned for a moment. “Oh, you mean the room where I was dreaming? We should… be pretty far already. I feel like we’ve walked at least most of a block.”

“Shirley, something isn’t right.” Dog suddenly reacted at this time. It stared tensely at the surrounding fog, its voice low. “Let’s stop for a moment.”

Shirley still had not caught up. She looked confused: “What is it?”

“A dream takes the dreamwalker’s subconscious base of knowledge as its ‘center’. In this dream, that base for you is that room, and all your memories and emotions are inside that room,” Dog explained quickly. “Everything outside the room is a ‘projected addition’ of the dream. In theory, the farther you go from that room, the more these projected scenes should drift away from reason and common sense. The edge of the dream should grow more absurd and dangerous, and there may even be cliffs that vanish into nothing. But we’ve already gone this far… and this dream still continues!”

Duncan listened and nodded slightly. He did not have such clear and complete theoretical knowledge as Dog, but his guesses were roughly the same.

Shirley finally understood. She took a light breath: “So… I should have already walked out of my own dream domain. In theory, this place should already be so twisted that I can’t recognize anything, or it should be a total void… So where are we now, exactly? Is this still my dream?!”

No one could answer Shirley's questions. Duncan could only look around with a thoughtful expression.

Everywhere he looked were charred streets. The district after the fire was like an ugly scar carved deep into the city-state, and this scar of burning stretched all the way to where his sight ended. He did not know how many more blocks it cut through ahead.

He looked in another direction and saw several tall buildings near the district. One factory's distillation tower stabbed straight up into the sky through the smoky haze. Pipes coiled around the surface of the tower, and its frame was jagged, like a strange mountain peak.

Duncan could not help staring at the tall distillation tower, thinking that if one stood atop it, perhaps one could overlook the entire fire zone.

All of a sudden, his gaze froze.

The scene Nina had once described to him rose in his mind:

From a very high place, overlooking the city after it had been burned by fire, with streets like a scar that cut across the entire city-state…

This was the scene Nina had seen in her dream—only from a different angle!

An astonishing idea flashed through Duncan's mind. He turned his head to look at Shirley: "We… may already have walked into another dream."

"Another dream?" Shirley was stunned. "Whose dream?"

"Nina's. Come with me." Duncan spoke briefly, then at once strode toward the distillation tower.

He did not summon AI into the dream to "give him a ride", because first, he did not know if that pigeon could enter this dream by walking through the Spirit Realm the way he had. Second, he still needed AI "on watch" outside,

to monitor whether any other supernatural force tried to interfere with his actions.

Luckily, the distillation tower was not far from this block. It belonged to a factory next door, and a straight alley connected the two streets.

Shirley followed in a daze. She still had no idea why Mr. Duncan said she had already walked into Nina's dream. Duncan, however, moved quickly, now and then lifting his head to look at the tall tower.

He was trying to find Nina's figure.

If this really was Nina's dream, then her figure should be standing on that distillation tower. It was already the highest building in sight here, and its location perfectly matched the conditions needed to look down on the entire burn zone.

But even when the two people and one hound were almost at the factory, Duncan still did not see any figure on the distillation tower.

He felt some doubt in his heart, but before he could think more, a strange feeling of being under a gaze suddenly came from not far away. It made him stop dead in his tracks.

Duncan lifted his head and looked toward the direction his senses pointed to. In his sight, a tall, thin figure in a strange black long coat, holding a black parasol, had appeared at some point at the corner of the street!

In this dreamscape full of traces of the fire, where embers still lingered on the street, such an umbrella-bearing stranger suddenly appearing was beyond strange. And this time, not only Duncan saw that figure; even Shirley beside him suddenly stopped.

"There's someone over there!" Shirley cried out.

“You see him too?” Duncan asked without thinking. As soon as his words fell, a murky, eerie muttering suddenly came from the direction of that figure.

It was not any language Duncan knew. The sound was so complex and twisted, with quivering tones and layer upon layer of echoes, that he even doubted it was any “language” at all. But he could still hear a hint of shock in it——

The umbrella-bearing “stranger” seemed very surprised. It was as if he had never expected to meet a few wandering “uninvited guests” here.

And the moment the muttering ended, that strange umbrella-bearing figure suddenly moved!

Duncan could not see clearly what the other did, but out of the corner of his eye he sharply noticed several dark shapes suddenly dart out from the hem of the stranger’s long coat. They were pure “shadows”, rushing along the nearby walls and street toward them. Right after that, the umbrella-bearing figure in the distance vanished into thin air. In the next second, his body appeared again by riding one of the shadows racing toward them, and he lunged straight at Shirley, as if by teleportation!

But by then Shirley had already reacted. Her mind was linked with the Abyssal Hound, and she had a reaction speed as fast as the hound’s. At the very moment that figure finished forming and had not yet acted, she suddenly raised her right hand——

“Anyway, beating the crap out of him first can’t be wrong!”

The girl yelled, with a strange excitement in her voice. The black chain in her hand creaked as she swung Dog in a wide circle and smashed it toward the enemy!

Chapter 134: Feast in the Fire

Shirley's way of fighting was the same as always.

It was simple, rough, and effective, with a wild, carefree air, like a hound running free across the sky. In the whistle of the iron chain, all beings were equal.

The eerie figure that had jumped here through the shadows clearly had not expected that the "Summoner Maiden" in front of him, the girl who carried Abyssal demons with her, was actually a close-combat fighter. By normal logic, the best move on seeing a spellcaster was to rush in at once and start a brawl. But if, after you closed the distance, the caster suddenly pulled out a meteor hammer, that was another matter entirely. So the scene Duncan had seen once before played out again:

The iron chain creaked. Shirley swung the dog down, and the dark figure was hit square on the spot. With a loud bang, he was sent flying backward, almost with a whistle in the air as he went.

With a boom, the figure crashed straight into a nearby building where the embers had not yet gone out. Dust and sparks burst upward, and then there was no more movement.

"Is that it?" The fight had gone so smoothly that Shirley herself had not reacted yet. She held Dog in one hand and peered into the distance, tense and wary. "Why did the impact feel…"

Before she finished, Dog suddenly cried out from the other end of the chain: "Watch out!"

Shirley’s muscles tensed all over. The next second, she finally noticed that the shadows at her feet had somehow grown a little darker than before. Then a blurred “whip” with no clear outline snapped out of the shadows!

The black whip sliced through the air with a vicious ripping sound, lashing straight for Shirley’s neck. At the last critical moment she twisted aside and jumped back, but it still struck her arm. Blood sprayed at once.

Shirley clicked her tongue and did not care at all about the pain. She backed off fast, and only then saw that part of her shadow had been left where she had just stood. From that slice of shadow, the strange tall, thin man holding an umbrella quickly rose up. She also finally saw what that “whip” that had hit her really was—it was a “limb” stretching out from the hem of his coat!

The shadow around him looked as if it carried a thick smoke. Inside it, flesh kept writhing and changing shape, rolling over and over, as if it was always in a state of constant rotting and rebirth. It was both disgusting and terrifying.

Shirley had only glanced once at that tentacle-like limb when a wave of nausea rose from deep in her chest. The next moment she heard the strange man under the umbrella give a low, muffled mutter. The bizarre “limb” that stretched from his coat hem turned into a whip again and lunged straight at her face.

She raised the chain in her hand on instinct, ready to swing Dog again. But at that moment, a ghostly green flame suddenly appeared at the edge of her vision.

The instant that green flame appeared, she noticed the tall, thin figure opposite her suddenly freeze, as if some fear from his deepest instinct had stopped him. In the next second, the figure quickly backed away. Thick black smoke churned under the black parasol, and low, blurry hisses kept coming from within. The green stream of fire spread outward, almost

brushing the edge of that smoke. In the faint glow of the spirit flame, the black smoke under the big umbrella was dyed with a pale, sickly color.

Shirley instinctively glanced toward Duncan. She saw that he was just standing quietly where he was, but phantom-like flames kept spreading out from him as the center. Wherever the flames reached, the buildings around them, the sparks drifting in the air, even the silhouettes of far-off structures, all slowly took on a ghostly green hue.

It was like some spreading plague. Wherever that strange fire went, everything was steadily being infected.

So this was the power of this big shot? Or was it only the tip of his strength?!

Shock and doubt rose in Shirley's heart, but she had no time to think. The attacker, now retreating as fast as he could, was clearly being suppressed and cowed by the spirit flame that filled the surroundings. Following the rule that you never hold back in a fight, Shirley took advantage of her weakened enemy, swung the chain again, and hurled the dog with all her strength at the attacker!

An even stranger feedback than before came up through Dog's senses. Shirley felt as if she had smashed into a puddle of rotten meat. She saw the figure with the black umbrella shatter under her blow. With a disgusting tearing sound, its black "coat" split apart. Several shapeless chunks of meat wrapped in thick smoke fell out of the clothing, then began to scurry all over the ground as if each piece had its own will, splitting into even smaller fragments as they ran.

The overlapping shrill cries of countless voices sounded from inside every fragment!

It was an utterly horrifying and bizarre sight. Charred, twisted alien limbs were torn to pieces and crawled, split, and fled in all directions across the street where the embers had not yet died. The shrieks were so sharp they seemed able to pierce mortal sanity. They rose and fell one after another, growing more and more numerous and more and more warped as the fragments kept splitting. In the end it felt as if the whole world were filled with their harsh, wailing screams.

For the first time since the fight started, Shirley felt a chill run through her. She gripped the chain in her hand, but had no idea how to use her usual “tactics” against these screaming fragments that kept splitting and writhing. Soon, though, she noticed that the scattered pieces were not trying to fight anymore—they were all fleeing.

Fleeing from the green flames that were still spreading.

By now they had split into hundreds, even thousands of pieces, like a swarm of black insects crawling and rushing along the street. They scrambled madly for the far end of the street through the gaps between the green flames. Again and again, some fragments were “caught” by the nearby spirit flame—one careless brush, a glancing touch from a spark was enough for flame to spread over them and burn them through in an instant.

But that burning was not the end. It was only the beginning. The fragments burned by the spirit flame did not die. Instead, they suddenly turned around and began to chase, attack, and gnaw on those chunks of flesh that had not yet escaped the fire zone and had not yet been touched by the green fire.

It all happened very fast. In barely half a minute, half of the scattered, fleeing chunks of flesh in the street had already been burned and tainted by the spirit flame. The pieces corrupted by the green fire hunted and devoured the “companions” that had been one body with them only a second before.

At the far end of the street, a faint wall of green fire had already closed together, sealing off every route of escape.

The burning street had become a hunting ground. The countless fragments split from the same black-clad attacker turned into a swarm locked in a death match. The shrieks that had risen and fallen without end finally began to fade, replaced by an even more horrifying sound—

The sound of chewing, spread across the whole street.

The attacker had tried to break himself apart to flee. Now he had become his own feast.

Goosebumps broke out all over Shirley's body, and she could feel Dog trembling as well. She shivered a little on the street littered with hot ash. Then, in the next second, she felt a warm hand press down on her shoulder.

"Don't be afraid," Duncan said softly, trying to comfort her. "Bugs are most afraid of fire."

Shirley's shoulder twitched. A very strange feeling rose in her heart. The comfort of being watched over and soothed by a powerful being mixed with the chill of being stared at by something unspeakable. She forced herself to look up at Duncan by her side, only to see him frowning.

"To be fair, it is a little disgusting," Duncan said, watching the "swarm" devouring one another. He spoke to Shirley from the heart: "Even I didn't expect it to end up like this."

[Who would believe that?!]

"Y-yeah… it is," Shirley said weakly, pretending she believed him. Whatever the big boss said was right. "It is a little disgusting…"

"At least it's almost over," Duncan said, sounding a little more relaxed.

Almost over.

The sound of spreading fire and feeding along the street was fading. Both the hunters and the hunted were finally running out of life and turning into heaps of ash that the wind blew away. The strange attacker thus faded into nothing. The spirit flame that had spread everywhere also began to draw back and die down.

Only then did Shirley finally swallow hard. She looked at the small drifting piles of ash and, gathering her courage, asked: “Is… is it over?”

But Duncan shook his head: “…Not necessarily.”

Shirley looked at him in surprise and confusion. She saw him walking forward. From a nearby mound of ash, the last chunk from the attacker crawled out. The shapeless, hateful flesh wobbled and squirmed. It still seemed to want to flee, but after just a few steps it stopped.

Duncan stopped in front of the fragment and bent down. A point of emerald flame danced between his fingers.

“I’ve heard many strange and creepy stories,” Duncan said slowly, explaining to Shirley. “Those stories taught me one thing. If you ever find that your enemy can split apart, you should assume the first one you met is only a split-off piece. You always have to assume there’s a main body hiding behind the split, waiting there so hack authors can write sequels.”

He tapped his fingertips and set the little green flame onto the surface of the last fragment.

“I don’t much like sequels,” he went on. “And I like it even less when some inexplicable main body hides behind the scenes and only jumps out to stab people after the ‘heroes’ have all let their guard down.”

The emerald flame flared up. The foul fragment gave a sudden shudder. Then many insect-like legs sprouted from its underside, holding it up as it wobbled to its feet.

Duncan slowly straightened and fixed his gaze on the attacker’s last remaining fragment.

“Go home,” he said. “Take my gift with you.”

Chapter 135: The End of the Dream

The spirit flame drew back and sank into the chunk of flesh.

The remains corrupted by the fire trembled as they crawled up, then crawled faster and faster, soon vanishing at the far end of the street.

That lump of mindless flesh had set out on the road home. But whether it could really make it back to some “main body”, or would simply burn out halfway and scatter on its own, or be intercepted and purified by something else, even Duncan had no way to know.

All he could do was clear away as many hidden dangers as lay within his reach.

From the moment Shirley started fighting that strange dark figure, he had been quickly analyzing what this “attacker” who appeared in the nightmare might be, and guessing at the pattern of its abilities. After seeing how it reacted to the spirit flame, he became more certain that this sudden attacker was probably only a split-off “pathfinder”.

Once it met the spirit flame, the attacker had no will to fight at all. Its first reaction had been to shatter and try to break out in every direction. That could be read as a panicked attempt to flee. But it could just as easily be read as a “pathfinder” trying to send information away. If this vast dream was truly woven by some hidden hand behind the scenes, then the arrival of an “intruder” like him was important intelligence.

Duncan watched the direction where the fragment had vanished, deep in thought. After it crawled a certain distance, the thing simply disappeared inside a burst of rising smoke and dust. That made him even more sure of his guess:

The sudden attacker knew this dream far better than he and Shirley did. In this place it had easier ways to move and knew some unseen “passages”. That was how the figure with the umbrella had managed to appear nearby without him sensing it at all.

By contrast, he, Shirley, and Dog were first-time “explorers” here. In the dream they were like headless flies, and finding those things that were hiding would not be easy.

But that was all right. The Fire Seed had already been spread, and a faint sense of connection was still flickering at the edge of his perception. Duncan believed that the flame he had sent out would bring something back. As long as that bit of spirit flame continued to spread, a clearer sense would form. Sooner or later, he would find some of those hidden beings in the spreading fire—and then Nina and Shirley would no longer have nightmares.

“Mr. Duncan…” Shirley looked at him, a little frightened by his sudden silence. She hesitated for a long time before finally mustering her courage and asking: “Do you know what that thing just now… was?”

She meant the attacker who had held the black umbrella.

“…Hard to say,” Duncan answered after thinking for a moment and shaking his head. Then he looked around at the burned-out street and added, thoughtful: “But do you remember that figure I mentioned before, the one standing at the edge of the square when we were coming back from the City Museum?”

“The one only you could see?” Shirley remembered at once. “Ah, so the one who attacked us just now was the one you saw…”

“I can’t be sure it’s the same one,” Duncan said, shaking his head. “But it is definitely the same ‘kind’. And I suspect it is related to those cultists who worship the Sun. Both times it showed up in scenes tied to ‘fire’. That is very suspicious.”

“So it’s connected to those cultists…” Shirley blinked, then reacted quickly: “Could it be the ‘Sun Spawn’ they talk about?!”

“Let’s suspect that for now, though we don’t have any real proof,” Duncan said with a quiet sigh. “But more than the attacker’s identity, I’m bothered by why that thing appeared in your dream and Nina’s dream… What link is there between the scene at the City Museum and your dreams?”

As he spoke, he lifted his head and let his gaze sweep over the tall tower.

He still could not see Nina at the top of the tower, but Duncan was almost certain that this was the place Nina had seen in her dream.

“This really is Nina’s dream?” Shirley looked around in wonder, full of disbelief. “How did you know?”

“She told me about this dream,” Duncan said, raising a hand to point at the nearby tower as he spoke. “In the dream, she was standing on top of the tallest distillation tower, looking down at the city-state after the fire. This spot is about two blocks away from the little house in your nightmare. I don’t know why, but your dreams are clearly linked to each other on a deeper level.”

Shirley was amazed and seemed to want to ask more. But all at once Dog beside her seemed to notice something: “Hey, Shirley, look. The umbrella that guy was holding is still here!”

Shirley and Duncan both looked toward where Dog was pointing. Sure enough, a big black umbrella was lying quietly by the side of the street.

Their attention had been on the attacker before. After his main body split apart, the umbrella had fallen by the road, and for a while none of them had noticed it.

Duncan walked over. At last he had a chance to examine the black parasol up close. But when he saw the inside of the canopy, he couldn't help letting out a small "Huh?"

He had imagined what the umbrella that the attacker had carried in his hand the whole time might be like. It might be an supernatural item etched with runes. Or it might be something that looked plain on the outside but was actually an Anomaly with many hidden traits. In any case, given the attacker's eerie and terrifying powers and form, the umbrella's style should have tended toward the sinister.

Yet everything under the canopy was completely different from what he had imagined—

He saw an extremely complex man-made structure. Delicate hexagonal grids were packed densely along the frame, forming something like a kind of… solar panel. In the deep purple gaps between the grids, he saw fine pipes and bundles of wiring. At the center of the umbrella there was a delicate device like some sort of control core that linked the handle to the surrounding grid array. Its precision and complexity far surpassed any steam engine in the city-state of Pland.

Duncan stared at the thing, stunned.

His first reaction was simple: it felt like technology.

This was definitely not an supernatural item. Its style was completely different from that of any "Anomaly", and it was not a machine built by the

city-states of today. This umbrella was a piece of technology, extremely delicate and complex.

It… came from a civilization beyond anything the modern city-states could understand!

“What is this thing?” Shirley asked in shock and confusion as she looked at the inner structure of the umbrella. She could not understand at all what it was and lacked Duncan’s knowledge from another world. To her it just looked a hundred times more complicated than she had imagined, to the point that it made her eyes swim. She reached out without thinking: “It looks kind of like…”

“Don’t touch it!” Dog cut her off at once. “It looks like some kind of Blasphemous Archetype.”

Shirley froze. “Blasphemous Archetype? What’s that supposed to be?”

“A creation from some forbidden history,” Dog said in a low, serious voice. “Something that shouldn’t exist in the Mortal Realm, but has been forced to stay in the Mortal Realm anyway. I don’t really know how to explain it to you… because I don’t know the principles behind it myself. Just remember this: in the long river of this world’s years, some stretches of history have been ‘locked’. The things born in those forbidden histories are Blasphemous Archetypes. In most cases, their very existence is harmful to living beings in the Mortal Realm. If you see one, do not touch it.”

Shirley quickly pulled her hand back, tense. Duncan gave Dog a thoughtful look and asked: “Is that also knowledge that Abyssal demons are born with?”

“More or less,” Dog said, shaking his head. “Not every Abyssal demon knows about these things. I just happened to be born closer to the head of the Abyssal Lord, so I ended up with a bit more knowledge in my skull.”

Duncan only grunted without answering, his eyes still on the strange black umbrella. Just then, as if it had lost some kind of “support”, the umbrella suddenly began to crumble and collapse before his eyes.

The delicate grid structure slowly turned transparent. The frame and wiring faded and turned into pale gray dust that scattered on the wind. The complex device at the core melted and flowed down like heated wax. Before it vanished completely, Duncan caught, out of the corner of his eye, a tiny line of text on one of its parts.

It was neither the common tongue of the city-states today nor any language he knew. Yet the meaning of the words still surfaced in his mind:

“K-22 Spectral Filter Crystal Core.”

A second later, the whole umbrella, including that last part, scattered away on the wind.

Duncan slowly straightened. Just then Shirley, standing beside him, gave a small cry: “Ah! What’s happening to my hand…”

Duncan looked at her arm and saw that not only her arm but her whole body was becoming transparent and blurry.

Shirley turned pale with fright. “Help help help help…”

“Help my ass!” Dog cut her off. “You’re about to wake up! This is the first time you’ve woken up properly from this dream—hurry up and thank Mr. Duncan!”

Only then did Shirley realize what was happening. She quickly looked at Duncan, and saw that his figure was also fading away in the dream.

Duncan smiled and waved to the girl in front of him: “Good night—and good morning. Don’t forget to wake Nina later so she can have breakfast.”

Chapter 136: An Ordinary Morning in the antique shop

A streak of morning light lit up the city-state of Pland, which had slept through the night. The Sun, locked in place by the double rune rings, slowly rose into the sky like a burning wheel. Under the great power of Vision 001, the things in the veil of night that did not belong to the mortal world finally began to fade.

The Shadows in the streets and alleys, the whispers in empty places, the murmurs hidden in the waves along the shore, the empty gaze lurking deep in narrow lanes, and the dreams that wrapped around people’s hearts.

Shirley opened her eyes.

She saw a ceiling that still felt unfamiliar. She saw sunlight coming in through the nearby window, falling on the low cabinet by the bed and on the desk beside it. The small room was clean and tidy, very simple, yet still much, much better than the place where she lived.

She smelled food. She heard a bit of noise from the direction of the kitchen. She saw Nina sprawled on the bed in a starfish pose. Today was a rest day. This girl could sleep in as much as she liked, because she had an “uncle” she could rely on, and there would be breakfast waiting when she woke up.

Shirley sat up in a daze. It took her a few seconds to fully remember why she was here, and what she had gone through in her dreams.

Then she reached over and pushed Nina: “Nina, time to get up… get up and wash up for breakfast.”

Nina answered in a sleepy mumble: “I’m so tired… let me sleep a little longer…”

Shirley froze for a moment. She suddenly didn’t know what she was supposed to do next.

She had been away from this kind of life for far, far too long. So long that there was a gap of a full eleven years. But she still vaguely remembered that she used to be like this too, and that she had once been allowed to live like this.

She slowly climbed out of bed and changed into her own clothes. As she listened to the sounds from outside, she reminded herself in her heart that this was not some peaceful, safe little home. In truth it was only a nest, dressed up like this for fun by a Subspace Shadow and his Retainer.

Yet this nest actually felt more like a “home” than the place where she and Dog lived.

Shirley drifted off in her thoughts, but Nina’s sudden shout cut through her wandering mind: “Wow! It’s already this late?!”

Shirley looked back and saw Nina sitting up in bed, her hair a total mess and her eyes wide open. Nina lifted her head to glance out the window, then finally noticed Shirley standing nearby. Her head wobbled a bit: “Shirley? Why are you… oh right, you slept over at my place last night…”

Then Nina jumped off the bed and cried out as she moved: “Ah, no time for this, I have to make breakfast…”

Halfway through her fussing she heard the noise from the kitchen and smelled the scent of food. She stopped, then seemed to wake up a second

time: “Oh, Uncle is making breakfast today… right, Uncle’s health has been better lately… no, wait! School! I’m going to be late for school!”

Before she even finished, Nina rushed toward her desk to pack her things. But after only two steps she suddenly stopped, raised her head, and looked at the calendar on the nightstand: “Wait, no, today is a rest day…”

Then she turned in a little circle where she stood and dove headfirst back into her pillow: “Then I’ll sleep two more minutes…”

Shirley just stood nearby, completely confused, watching Nina jump out of bed and go through a dizzying series of actions, only to end up right back where she started as if nothing had happened. She never even found a chance to say a word. Only when Nina flopped onto the bed again did Shirley carefully move closer. But before she could speak, Nina suddenly sprang up again and stretched hard: “Ah, now I’m awake.”

Shirley: “…?”

“Shirley, what’s wrong?” Nina turned her head, now full of energy as she looked at Shirley. “Why that face?”

Shirley asked: “Do you… wake up like this every morning?”

Nina looked blank: “Huh? Like what?”

“I mean…” Shirley waved her hands in the air, as if she didn’t know how to explain. “You jump up first, then do this, then that, and then this and this…”

“Oh, I get really muddled when I first wake up,” Nina somehow pulled the right meaning out of Shirley’s strange, abstract gestures. She nodded while talking and went to change her clothes. “But now I’m totally awake! Oh, right, Shirley, did you sleep well last night? I toss and turn a lot when I sleep. I didn’t bother you, did I?”

“I…” Shirley had just opened her mouth when a rush of memories suddenly flooded in. She remembered that closed little room, that early morning, the sound of footsteps leaving and the door being locked, and then the Abyssal Hound breaking down the door. But after that came an unbelievable grand adventure, a bold exploration.

A bit eerie, a bit scary, but… pretty impressive.

“I slept very well,” she said with a little smile. “Actually, I move around a lot in my sleep too. Dog always says I’ll tear my own bed apart one day while I’m sleeping.”

“Uncle used to say the same thing about me,” Nina said as she finished changing. She gave a big yawn, then stepped forward, grabbed Shirley’s hand, and pulled her toward the door. “Come on, let’s eat first, I’m a little hungry.”

Shirley let herself be dragged out the door in a muddle. Then she saw Duncan coming out of the kitchen, wiping his hands on his apron. It was clear he had just finished cooking.

“Mr. Duncan…” Shirley tensed up again without even thinking. Even though she had seen it with her own eyes, the thought that a being like him had just been working in the kitchen made the whole thing feel strange and wrong to her. But she quickly forced that feeling down and lowered her head to greet him honestly: “Good morning.”

Just like the big boss had told her, she treated this place as a normal, ordinary place and tried to act like a normal person visiting someone else’s home.

Even though Shirley herself had no idea what “normal” guests were supposed to do when visiting someone, at least it was never wrong to say good morning.

“What are we having for breakfast?” Nina was already heading toward the kitchen, stretching her neck to peek around Duncan’s back as she walked. “It smells so good!”

“I fried some little sausages, bought them on my way back yesterday,” Duncan said offhand. Then he pressed down on Nina’s head and firmly turned her toward the washroom. “Go wash your hands first!”

Then he looked over at Shirley, hands on his hips: “You too. Don’t just stand there. Go wash your hands, and wash your face while you’re at it.”

Shirley jumped a little, then hurried after Nina to wash her hands and face. She was the first to finish and came back to Duncan, holding out her hands: “…They’re clean.”

As soon as she said it, she felt embarrassed. She suddenly thought she looked really silly. She was almost an adult, yet after washing her hands she actually held them out like this to show the Lord. She felt more like a seven-year-old child than a seventeen-year-old. She didn’t even know why her brain had suddenly shorted out like that.

But Duncan did not mind at all. He only nodded, then turned back toward the kitchen as he asked in a casual tone: “How did you sleep?”

Shirley lowered her head: “Mm, fine… better than before.”

“Did the wounds you took in the dream affect the Mortal Realm?” Duncan asked again.

Shirley was startled. She suddenly remembered that she really had been struck once by that strange attacker in the dream, like being hit with a “whip”. She quickly lifted her left arm and saw a faint scar there.

Because of her powerful self-healing, the scar had almost finished closing by now and she barely felt anything. But there was no doubt that when she

was hurt in the dream last night, her body in the Mortal Realm had taken the same injury.

And at that time she had been trapped in the dream, so even though her body in the Mortal Realm was hurt, she had not been able to wake up.

Duncan saw the mark on Shirley's arm. His gaze paused for a moment, then he gave a small nod.

It went against common sense, but it was not beyond what he had expected.

That strange dream had never been just a simple dream.

"It seems that getting hurt in that dream will also affect the Mortal Realm at the same time," he said to Shirley very seriously. "In the future, if I'm not with you, don't explore that dream on your own. Your combat power is strong, but it doesn't work well against that splitting monster."

Shirley nodded quickly: "Mm, I understand."

Duncan thought for a moment, then added: "Also, if you get trapped in that nightmare again, you can call me directly."

Shirley blinked, as if she hadn't reacted yet: "Call you?"

"Call my name, the full name I told you in the dream," Duncan said calmly. "Or call the Vanished. It's best if you call near glass, mirrors, or other things with a reflective surface. Then I can hear you more clearly."

Shirley listened, and suddenly something clicked in her mind. At the same time, through the mental link between her and Dog, she felt a wave of nervous emotion coming from Dog's side.

"You want… to make me your Retainer?" she asked, lifting her eyes, tense and troubled.

“I don’t know what a Retainer really is,” Duncan said. “I’m not asking you to offer me anything. You’re Nina’s friend, and now you’re working with me too. I’m just giving you a bit of extra protection.”

Shirley drew in a breath, but still didn’t dare answer too quickly. Just then, Nina’s cheerful voice sounded from the kitchen doorway: “What are you talking about?”

“You don’t have to answer me now,” Duncan said quietly to Shirley, then looked up at Nina. “Why did washing your hands take so long?”

“I couldn’t clean the gunk at the corner of my eyes,” Nina rubbed her eyes. “I rubbed till they almost hurt…”

“Drink more water in the next few days,” Duncan said helplessly, giving this young lady a quick look. Then, as if in passing, he asked, “By the way, did you have that dream again last night? The one where you stand somewhere high and look down at a fire?”

“No,” Nina thought for a moment and shook her head. “Last night I dreamed my belly was being pressed down by a horse, and then by a cow. It was so heavy… Uncle, why did you suddenly ask?”

“It’s nothing. I just remembered that psychiatrist is coming to visit again today,” Duncan shook his head and put away the thoughts on his face. “Let’s eat.”

Chapter 137: “Two Descendants”

North of the city-states of Pland and Lunsa, beyond the busy “Great Cross route” where merchants sailed back and forth, cold air hung forever over a sea known as the Frost Sea. Under this strange chill that seemed as if it would never fade, the Frost Sea took on a look very different from other waters.

Here, the sea had a deep, heavy quality, sharply different from the warmer seas. Small chunks of drift ice often appeared where currents met islands. Mysterious giant icebergs rose from below the surface from time to time, turning into temporary barriers or moving pieces of land. For some seafarers struggling to make a living in the Frost Sea, they became markers on their routes or emergency havens in a storm. Strange cold mists, icy winds, and phantom lights were also unique sights here, giving birth to countless weird legends, so that even the two main city-states on this sea, Frostholm and Cold Harbor, were wrapped in a cloak of mystery.

But compared to the great icebergs that could be tracked and predicted, and compared to the supernatural Visions that in most cases existed only in rumor, what the captains who lived off the Frost Sea talked about most often was a different thing. It was a terrible fleet that had been active for half a century, a real force wrapped in layers of myth and fog— the Sea Mist Fleet led by Tyrian, son of Duncan Abnomar, whose reach spread across a third of the sea routes in the Frost Sea.

On the edge of an island sealed and hidden by special sea currents and thick fog, an iron-gray, hard-lined ironclad warship lay quietly in a dock. Service

crew and sailors moved busily around it, loading fuel and resupplying fresh water and ammunition.

If someone who knew a bit of Frostholm's history stood here, they would notice at a glance that the sailors still wore Frostholm navy uniforms from half a century ago. They would also notice the white badges on their shoulders or chests— in Frostholm's tradition, those badges were a sign of mourning.

In the captain's cabin on the upper deck of the warship, a man in a black navy cloak was reading through some documents.

He was thin, with a high nose and deep-set eyes. His neat short black hair was trimmed close. Over his left eye he wore a black eyepatch made of some unknown leather. That eyepatch, almost a symbol of a pirate, made his already gloomy face look even sharper and more dangerous. The shape of his brow and features faintly resembled that of the "ghost captain" who once made the world tremble.

A large parrot with bright, patterned tail feathers perched on a wooden stand nearby. It was staring with full attention at a brass device beside the thin man. The device was a set of precise, complex lenses. A ring of levers and small lenses surrounded it, and in the center sat a large scrying crystal. It looked very luxurious and gave off a strong sense of mystery.

The thin man spoke without looking up: "Polly, if you touch that, I'll send you to the Radiant Star next month to keep those puppets and ghosts company."

"Ah, cruel!" the big parrot screeched at once, shaking the wooden stand. "Ah, cruel! Tyrian is such a cruel captain!"

"…I really should find out which bastard taught you that line," Tyrian Abnomar frowned. "Can't you say something else?"

The large parrot flapped its wings proudly. “Polly learned it herself! Polly learned it herself!”

Tyrian rubbed his forehead. “Damn, and there’s that line too…”

Just then, a knock on the door suddenly came from the side, breaking off the exchange between Tyrian and the parrot.

“Come in,” Tyrian said, turning his head.

The door to the captain’s cabin opened, and a tall, bald man walked in.

His skin was pale, like the skin of a corpse that had been dead for a long time. A permanent, murky gloom lingered in his eyes. A faint smell of the sea clung to him, mixed with a chill that seemed to come from a grave.

A moving corpse. A body that had stayed behind in the Mortal Realm.

Tyrian looked at the “Living dead” who had entered: “Aiden, how much fuel has been loaded?”

“Almost finished, Captain,” the tall bald man, Aiden, lowered his head slightly. His voice was hoarse and rough, and a thin white mist of cold air drifted from his mouth and nose as he spoke. “The boilers are already heating up.”

“Good,” Tyrian gave a small nod. “Any movement from Cold Harbor?”

“As quiet as a rock,” Aiden said, with a touch of contempt in his tone. “They don’t dare step into our waters. Even with only half the Sea Mist Fleet left in the Frost Sea, those cowards don’t have the courage to cross the route.”

“They’re smart, very good at calculating gains and losses. They were like that half a century ago,” Tyrian said with a small smile. “Go get ready. We’ll leave port on time.”

“Yes, Captain.”

The First Mate, who carried the cold aura of death, pushed open the door and left the room. Tyrian’s gaze slowly followed him out, then drew back.

His First Mate was a Living dead. In fact, in the entire Sea Mist Fleet, other than Tyrian himself, the “Immortal”, every member was this kind of Living dead, stuck halfway between the living and the dead.

His loyal subordinates had served faithfully in this fleet for half a century.

In a way, he himself, a man who could not die because of the curse of Subspace, was no different from his crew members.

Tyrian shook his head. At that moment, the brass device by his hand suddenly made a mechanical sound. He turned toward it and saw the complicated levers and lenses moving and shifting quickly, focusing their combined point on the scrying crystal at the center. A second later, the scrying crystal gave off a faint light, and a blurred image began to form inside it.

A young lady with long, straight black hair and a black silk dress appeared in the scrying crystal. Her delicate features carried a hint of cold, mysterious charm, with a quiet, mage-like air. Behind her, many magical mechanisms were running on their own, and tiny points of ghostly, phosphorus-blue fire floated in the air like scattered stars.

“Lucretia,” Tyrian glanced at the lady in the scrying crystal and nodded slightly. “I really didn’t expect you to remember to send a greeting before your elder brother sets out.”

The young lady in the scrying crystal was just about to speak. She froze when she heard Tyrian’s words: “You’re leaving today?”

Tyrian frowned: “…You didn’t contact me because I’m leaving today?!”

“No,” the lady in the scrying crystal, with her mage-like mystery, calmly shook her head. “My Deep Sea detection device exploded.”

The corner of Tyrian’s mouth twitched. Then he heard his younger sister continue: “Everything else is easy to repair. I just can’t find a replacement for the core crystal lens.”

Tyrian kept his face blank.

“Do you have any new ones over there?” Lucretia asked. “I’ll trade border minerals and samples.”

“Spirit Realm lenses that match your precision needs can only be made in two city-states,” Tyrian finally could not stop a sigh. “The main trade channels are controlled by the Truth Academy. The number that actually reaches the outside world is very, very, very limited. It’s only been two months since you broke your last detector…”

“I found some very interesting samples. They may have drifted up from the Abyssal Deep sea area,” Lucretia said.

“Abyssal Deep samples won’t do either,” Tyrian said. “Even though those things really can be sold to the Truth Academy…”

“I also collected phantoms left over after the Border Collapse.”

“That’s not…” Tyrian held his forehead in one hand, feeling a headache. “The main thing is that right now I really don’t know where I’m supposed to find you a whole new set of lenses…”

Lucretia thought for a moment. “Rob someone?”

“I can’t always rely on robbery,” Tyrian sighed again. “The Sea Mist Fleet is preparing to run formal business. Right now we mainly make money by collecting protection fees…”

“Oh, then forget it,” Lucretia finally shrugged. The first half of her sentence let Tyrian breathe a little easier, but the second half made this famous Pirate Lord tense up again. “Then I’ll ask again tomorrow.”

“You…” Tyrian started, then gave up. “Forget it. I can’t stop your exploration plan anyway,” he said at last with helpless resignation. (In just these few minutes, even he didn’t know how many times he had sighed.) “Tell me about your situation, my ‘honorable’ great explorer younger sister. You wander all year along the border of the civilized world. Have you really found any signs that our world is heading toward Doomsday?”

“I can hear the mockery, brother,” Lucretia said with a straight face. “You’ve always looked down on my sense of urgency. You’ve never truly cared about what I’ve found on the border. I can understand. You focus on more practical matters. That is why I’m even more grateful that you still help me as much as you can, even when you don’t understand. But you must not forget our father… the warning he gave.”

“That our world is nothing but a pile of dying embers…” Tyrian leaned back in his chair and spoke softly, like a sigh. “To this day I still don’t know what he saw on that day. But one clear fact is that he was already mad when he gave that warning. And now you’re repeating what he did back then, even trying to uncover the truth that drove him insane.”

Tyrian shook his head and looked seriously at the figure in the scrying crystal. “Lucretia, one Vanished in this world is already bad enough.”

Chapter 138: The Radiant Star

Wasn’t one ship like the Vanished in this world already bad enough…

In the Divination room, lit only by dim candlelight, Lucretia sat quietly in a high-backed chair padded with velvet cushions. She used her gaze on the scrying crystal resting on the table, yet for some reason her thoughts drifted away, back to something long ago, to an afternoon a century in the past…

That figure, already a little blurred in her memory, stood on the deck, facing the sunlight that was slowly sinking toward the horizon. His tall body seemed to turn into wavering, unreal flames in the sunset. In a low, heavy voice she had never heard before, he told her:

“Our world is nothing but a heap of dying embers…”

By now, she of course knew that even then, Father had already fallen into madness. Soon after, he completely abandoned his humanity and chose to embrace the “divine blessing” of Subspace. Yet she still sometimes wondered: if that day she had talked with Father a little longer, if she had seriously asked what he meant by those words, asked what exactly he had seen at the edge of the world, would things have unfolded differently afterward?

Perhaps Father would still not have escaped his insane end. Perhaps the birth of the Vanished was already a “fixed fact” carved into the long river of years, something no one could change. But at least, she would know how it had all happened. She would know where she should go to seek the truth—rather than, like now, steering a ship under the curse, wandering fruitlessly

in this border region where even the Holy See's inspectors were unwilling to go deep…

"Lucretia, are you still listening?"

Tyrian's voice suddenly came from the scrying crystal, pulling the young lady who had been staring blankly at the table back to herself. Lucretia shook her head, pushing her tangled thoughts aside for now.

"Big Brother," she looked solemnly at Tyrian inside the scrying crystal, her tone turning serious. "Do you still remember what Father said before his last voyage to the border? The time he did not let us go with him…"

"Of course I remember." Tyrian nodded. "He said he had found a clue to Anomaly 000 and was going to find 'a cure for this world.' Back then he not only refused to take the two of us, he also refused the escort of several other warships. And after he and the Vanished returned, both he and that ship were no longer quite the same."

"Yes. All the crew members on the Vanished stopped speaking, as if they were under a silence curse. Father was still clear-minded enough to talk with us. He said he hadn't found Anomaly 000, and even if Anomaly 000 did exist, it was not the origin point of the world's distortion. The so?called cure had never existed from the very beginning. After that, until the day he stood on the deck in the sunset and told us 'the world is a heap of embers,' he never again mentioned anything related to that border voyage…"

Tyrian in the scrying crystal stayed silent. After an unknown length of time, it was Lucretia who spoke again: "After that, I went and contacted the Holy See fleets that patrolled near the border. That included the Flamebearer, the Deep Sea priests, the scholars of the Truth Academy, and even those gloomy death cultists. I asked them about Anomaly 000, but they all said there was no such thing as an anomaly or Vision numbered zero…"

“I also asked around,” Tyrian said in a low voice. “I got the same answer as you. In this world, there is no anomaly or Vision numbered zero. It’s not that it doesn’t exist yet. There simply isn’t an empty slot for it.

“The very first list that leaked from the Nameless King’s tomb already set down all the numbers. Unfound or still?forming anomalies and Visions all have their own reserved slots waiting to be filled. Even things like the Mycelium Bottle and the Fungal Isle, which evolved over the course of history, were later matched to positions that had been planned ahead of time. But at the start of that entire list, there is no slot for number zero at all…

“That’s why I say Father must already have been unstable before he sailed for the border. He could not possibly have been ignorant of this information.”

Here, Tyrian suddenly stopped. Then he raised his head and fixed his gaze on Lucretia in the scrying crystal. His expression grew very serious: “Why bring this up all of a sudden? We haven’t talked about it for half a century. What are you planning to do?”

“…Relax. I won’t dive headfirst into that grand wall of fog like Father did.” Lucretia rarely showed much expression, but this time she still smiled. “I’m looking for clues Father left behind. I’m not trying to walk his old path.”

Tyrian stayed silent for a moment, then slowly nodded. “…Good.”

Lucretia did not speak for a while. The two siblings, separated by a vast distance and rarely meeting face to face over the past century, each had their own thoughts. Only when the faint sound of a distant foghorn from the Sea Mist came through the scrying crystal did Lucretia suddenly break the silence: “You really are going to Pland? Just because of that governor’s ‘invitation’?”

“The ‘invitation’ isn’t important. I don’t care about that city?state’s so? called safety problem. But the governor said in his letter that the Vanished had appeared again in the Mortal Realm, and he sounded very certain. I have to go see for myself.” Tyrian’s face was solemn. “That ship hasn’t shown itself in almost half a century. For it to appear again now is very suspicious.”

Lucretia thought for a moment, then asked: “You ran into the Vanished once fifty years ago. I remember you were still in Frostholm then… was what you saw back then really the Vanished?”

“…Absolutely. Hard as it is to believe, it was truly the Vanished.” Tyrian’s voice grew low. “I wouldn’t mistake the position of even a single mast, or the layout of a single set of rigging.”

“Then… the one standing on that ship back then, was that really ‘Father’?”

Tyrian lowered his head slightly, hiding his face in shadow. “…It was him. Though I’d much rather that thing wasn’t him.”

Lucretia looked at her Big Brother in the scrying crystal. After hesitating for a moment, she spoke softly: “Be very careful. If that really is him, you’ll be in great danger.”

“I know.” Tyrian let out a quiet sigh. “He’s already a frenzied ghost completely twisted by Subspace. I would never let my guard dow—”

Lucretia shook her head, expressionless. “No, I mean if that really is Father, once he sees you turned the Sea Mist into a big lump of iron, he’ll hit you even harder than he did fifty years ago.”

Tyrian froze, then glared at once. “What is that supposed to mean? This is an efficient modern refit! What’s wrong with steam boilers and rapid?fire guns? And you have some nerve to talk. At least I kept part of the original.

Does your ship still have even a single plank from the Radiant Star of those days…”

The scrying crystal went dark.

Lucretia let out a quiet breath and rose from her chair.

Her Big Brother was still in good shape. A little provocation and he was full of energy, and he still had a strong curiosity about modern things. That was good.

In a long, endless life, what one feared most was the decline of the mind and the decay of the soul.

Light footsteps came from the dimness, mixed with the rubbing of mechanical parts and clockwork. Lucretia turned toward the sound and saw a clockwork automaton with the shape of a woman walking toward her. The automaton looked about sixty percent like her, yet its whole body was made of obvious rivets and mechanical joints. Its steel?and?ceramic shell had been shaped into a maid’s dress. In the dim light, it looked rather eerie.

As the automaton walked, the spring mechanism on her back kept clicking softly. She came to Lucretia, offered the black tea in her hands, and her jointed mouth clacked as she spoke in a slightly stiff female voice: “Mistress, please have some tea.”

“Thank you.” Lucretia took the cup and asked casually: “Lunie, where are we now?”

The clockwork automaton named Lunie answered: “The Radiant Star has just passed ‘Fog Horn Isle’. We are now sailing along the edge of the Eternal Veil. Do you wish to enjoy the view outside the window?”

“…Open the dome.” Lucretia took a sip of black tea and set the cup back on Lunie’s tray. “It’s already morning. I should bask in the Sun.”

“Yes, Mistress.”

Lunie bowed slightly and backed away.

At the same time as the automaton’s voice faded, the entire Divination room gave a slight tremor.

The squeaking of moving machinery rose in a continuous chain. The humming and grinding of giant springs and magic units working together sounded like a piece of music. Driven by countless gears and rails, the walls of the room began to pull back and unfold. The room that had been dim and candlelit was suddenly flooded with sunlight. In the sunlight, the entire room opened slowly like a mechanical flower, and in the end bloomed into something like a high stage.

This was the upper deck of the Radiant Star. The room where the “Sea Witch” Lucretia resided had blossomed into a towering stage at the very front of the deck. Around this blooming mechanical flower, one could see the full shape of the Radiant Star—

The ship had been split in half.

The front half of the vessel had been completely rebuilt. Countless runes and magical devices covered the hull. It looked less like a ship and more like a giant magical mechanism. Strange materials taken from the border region or from the sea had reshaped the deck. Everything in sight shimmered with a faint, bizarre, dreamlike color, as if a never?ending magic ritual was running between the dense arrays and clusters of crystals.

The rear half of the ship was completely different. There, half of the hull had become almost ghost?like and half transparent. A thin veil of shifting light wrapped the stern of the Radiant Star. In the floating glow, one could faintly see that part of the structure still kept the vessel’s original form—

A sailing warship built a century ago, with a style faintly similar to the Vanished.

Chapter 139: Those Who Guard the Border

A century ago, the Radiant Star, like the Sea Mist, had once been an escort warship of the Vanished.

Yet very few people knew what these two legendary warships had gone through after their break with the Vanished, or how they had step by step become what they were now.

The Sea Mist, under the command of “Steel Vice Admiral” Tyrian, had, after many twists and turns, once become the main warship of the city?state of Frostholm. People called it “the Unsinkable” and “the Breathing Corpse.” That ship had been heavily damaged many times in battle. Yet it was as if an undying soul ruled over it, dragging it back again and again from a fate that should have sunk it for good. After one refit after another that almost broke the rules of shipbuilding, it gradually turned into a steel behemoth.

Legend said that ship even fed directly on steel and seabed ore. During night voyages when no one kept watch on it, it would slowly grow new turrets and armor plates on its own.

As for the Radiant Star, which had passed into the hands of the “Sea Witch” Lucretia, it was wrapped in an even thicker veil of mystery because it rarely approached the civilized world. In truth, apart from a few members of the Explorer Association and the Holy See fleets that often patrolled the border,

the ordinary captains on the Boundless Sea had no chance at all to see what this ship looked like.

Those who had been lucky enough to see the Radiant Star described it like this:

“It clearly no longer fully belongs to our Mortal Realm. That ship has truly sunk at least once and has lost half its structure in the Boundless Sea. Half of its hull looks like a ghost, showing its shape from a century ago. The other half, under the power of that witch, has been twisted into strange and bizarre forms. The bow is hung with cursed things from the Deep Sea, and machines and magic equipment clang and rattle everywhere. The crew has long since died. Soulless clockwork automatons and cursed little dolls run about on the deck instead of normal seafarers.

“Without a doubt, that ship is a corpse still sailing the sea—or rather, half a deformed corpse dragging half a soul.”

Lucretia’s gaze swept slowly across her flagship, and she gave a small, satisfied nod.

The Radiant Star was in good condition. Her crew members were all in good spirits.

She knew how the world described her ship—and she also knew how people described her Big Brother’s Sea Mist. She knew many captains feared the two of them as siblings, second only to their fear of their Father, who had returned from Subspace.

But she did not care. She usually dealt with very few humans, and those people either had great courage or deep knowledge, or at least had gone through some real adventures. Those people could talk with her in a calm and rational way. That was enough.

She and her Big Brother were still seen as part of the Mortal Realm, still seen as “standing on the side of humans,” and even though many believed the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star were under the curse, that view of them did not change.

In the end, there were simply too many cursed things in this world. Almost every city?state lived side by side with countless anomalies and Visions. Some even described modern human civilization itself as “cursed.” In a world where everything was under the curse, there was no harm in leaving some room for two strange ships.

Lucretia walked down from her stage that bloomed like a mechanical flower and headed toward the bow deck. Two clockwork puppets with comical masks clanked past in front of her, and a big little doll sewn from velvet, silk, and ribbons ran up from the side. It squeaked in a shrill voice: “Mistress! Mistress! Good morning! Good morning!”

“It’s almost noon,” Lucretia said casually. She stepped past the little doll and stood at the bow, gazing into the distance.

She saw a huge gray?white wall of fog, like a vast curtain at the World’s Edge, standing far out on the sea. It linked the sky with the ocean, magnificent and awe?inspiring.

That was “the border.”

The grand wall of fog had many names—the world’s border, the grand mist, the fog barrier. Its most formal name was the “Eternal Veil.”

But Lucretia preferred to simply call it “the border.”

Father had called it that in those days.

Under normal conditions, the Eternal Veil was like a ring wall that covered all known seas. It only rose and fell slightly within a relatively fixed range. It did not shrink or expand. It was just a stable natural phenomenon.

But on rare occasions, a part of its barrier would suddenly “appear” within the territory of civilization and, as it collapsed inward, would trigger terrible disasters. This wall of fog, which appeared out of nowhere and then collapsed in the Mortal Realm, would drag the nearby solid matter toward the deep layers of the world and could even open a door straight into Subspace. This terrible disaster was called “Border Collapse.”

For captains who often sailed the Boundless Sea, Border Collapse was something even more terrifying than storms, whirlpools, or mass hysteria.

The only good news was that such collapses did not happen often.

Lucretia spent most of her time in the border region. She watched the border and studied it, trying to summarize the rules of the thick fog’s movements and to find the cause of its sudden inward collapses. A hundred years ago, her Father had done the same.

Yet to this day, no one had uncovered the secrets of the Veil.

What had Father discovered back then? Or what had he “heard” that made him suddenly decide to pass through that thick fog and search for Anomaly Zero?

Lucretia drew her gaze back from the border.

In the borderlands, one should not keep one’s gaze on the Eternal Veil for too long. There was no clear proof that the thick fog could devour minds or influence thoughts, but on the Boundless Sea, especially far from the civilized city?states, staring too long at any target on the sea carried a natural risk.

Who knew what kinds of things could spread along with “gaze” in this place.

A long, mellow whistle broke the stillness of the border sea.

Lucretia followed the sound and saw tiny shadows appear at the edge of the great fog wall. Those shadows slowly drew closer until they showed the outlines of warships.

They were three ships, the latest ironclad warships, driven by powerful steam cores. They were sailing toward the position of the Radiant Star, but this was only a chance meeting.

The other side blew their whistle first. It was a greeting. In this borderland, no matter who you met, as long as it was not an Eldritch God from Subspace, it was something to be glad about.

“Mistress,” Lunie walked over. A stiff voice came from inside the clockwork maid. “It is a patrol squadron of the Holy See… confirmed by sight, Flamebearer Church.”

“…Only the Flamebearer and those storm cultists would patrol this close to the Eternal Veil,” Lucretia said softly. “They really are a bunch of people who don’t care whether they live.”

“Should we answer them?” Lunie asked.

“…Blow the whistle back,” Lucretia said in a low voice. “To the civilization we still keep alive.”

…

There were not many customers in the antique shop today. Aside from an unremarkable pair of ornaments sold in the morning, no one had stepped through the door.

Nina sat beside the counter with a mechanics textbook in her hands, studying the fine and complex mechanical structures drawn on the pages. From time to time she picked up the notebook next to her and sketched things in the blank spaces. Duncan sat behind the counter. While curiously

flipping through Nina’s history book, he jotted down a few notes in his own notebook.

Only Shirley had nothing to do. She wanted to go home but did not dare. She wanted to talk to Nina, but she could not understand what Nina was studying. After wandering bored among the shelves for a long time, she finally could not help muttering: “Is reading really that fun?”

“Of course it is!” Nina looked up. “And my final exams are coming. I have to hurry and review.”

Duncan also looked up at Shirley. “If you’re really that bored, you can find a book to read… I’ve got a brief history of the Age of City?States here. Do you want to read it?”

Shirley glanced at the books near Duncan’s hand, opened her mouth, and showed an awkward expression. “I… I can’t read…”

Duncan stopped turning the pages. Beside him, Nina also raised her head in surprise.

“Why are you so shocked?” Shirley widened her eyes as if hurt. “I… I already told you I sneaked into school. Is it really that strange that I’ve never gone to school? I was raised by a dog…”

Duncan really was a little surprised, but seeing Shirley’s reaction, he felt more moved than anything else. “You can’t read, and you still had the nerve to sneak into school. I don’t know if I should say you’re too confident, or that you trust that mutt’s unreliable cognitive interference ability too much.”

“Dog’s cognitive interference is very reliable!” Shirley argued at once. “It’s just… just…”

The girl’s face turned a little red. She didn’t seem to dare finish that sentence. Duncan guessed what she wanted to say and smiled slightly: “You

already dare to argue with me. See? There’s nothing to be afraid of, is there?”

“That’s right, that’s right, my uncle is very kind,” Nina, the silly girl who understood nothing, chimed in beside them. “He was pretty irritable for a while before, but he’s fine now, isn’t he?”

“I…” Shirley opened her mouth, but suddenly didn’t know how to talk to this “uncle and niece.” She held it in for a long time and still couldn’t manage a second word.

Duncan shook his head with a smile. Just as he was about to say something more, a faintly familiar presence suddenly appeared in his senses.

Duncan paused for a moment. The next second, he knew exactly who that presence belonged to Vanna. That young Inquisitor was approaching the antique shop… and fast!

Chapter 140:

Duncan sensed Vanna’s presence rushing toward the antique shop. It did not come in a straight line. It kept changing direction and even paused in strange places.

What was an Inquisitor who lived in the Upper City doing suddenly coming to this Lower City antique shop? And why was her route so strange?

The moment the aura of that young Deep Sea Inquisitor appeared in his senses, Duncan frowned a little and, without thinking, glanced at Shirley.

Was she here for Shirley? Had the Deep Sea Church finally found the summoner in the city who traveled with Abyssal demons? Or was she here for him? He had always acted very carefully. He had left no clues that could point to the Vanished. At most, the original identity of this body as a Suntist might be exposed… but that still should not alarm a full Inquisitor, right?

The way that aura approached—fast yet winding—did not look at all like someone just strolling past. It felt full of purpose.

His thoughts rose and fell in an instant. Duncan quietly looked at Nina, who was reading beside him, then stood up and walked toward the front door of the antique shop.

Shirley noticed his movement and followed him without thinking: “Mr. Duncan? What’s going on…?”

“Stay in the shop.” Duncan gave Shirley, who no matter how you looked at it should count as a Heretic, a look and told her to stay where she was. Then

he went to the door and looked toward the direction of the aura he sensed.

Then he understood why Vanna's aura was getting closer so fast—

She had come by car.

A dark gray car driven by a steam engine screeched to a stop at the shop's door. The door opened and two people stepped down. One was Vanna. She had changed into regular clothes, but her height still drew the eye at once. The other was the psychiatrist he had met once before, Miss Heidi.

Duncan: "…"

He thought for a moment about all the wild scenes he had imagined after sensing an aura rush toward him. Maybe he should stop assuming every supernatural matter involved people in spotless white robes drifting in and out like the wind. Thinking about it now, those brief pauses while Vanna came over were probably just her waiting at traffic lights…

Then he saw the psychiatrist lady wave to him in high spirits and greet him cheerfully: "Mr. Duncan!"

Duncan's mouth twitched. When he saw Vanna in ordinary clothes, he already knew he had overthought things. Even so, as he walked up to them, he deliberately gave this Inquisitor a few extra looks and showed just the right amount of surprise: "And this is…?"

"Ah, you must recognize her. There's no one in this city who doesn't," Heidi said with a teasing smile. "Our respected Inquisitor, Miss Vanna. But she's off duty today, so relax a little—she's my friend. When she heard what happened at the City Museum, she insisted on coming along to thank you in person…"

"Friend?" This time Duncan's surprise had some real feeling in it. He really had not expected this. "I didn't think you would bring such a big shot over…"

“Calling me a ‘big shot’ is a bit much, Mr. Duncan,” Vanna said.

It seemed she had been quietly sizing up the antique shopkeeper from the start. She finally spoke with a slight smile. Her voice was a little hoarse and low, with a hint of magnetism. But to Duncan, this was not the first time he had heard the Inquisitor’s voice.

“Just treat me as an ordinary guest. As Heidi said, I’m off duty today. I came mainly to thank you for saving Heidi at the City Museum, and also to learn a few things… Don’t worry, it’s nothing like a formal interrogation.”

Learn a few things?

Duncan’s expression did not change. He kept his usual friendly smile, stepped aside, and invited the two special visitors into the shop: “Then let’s not stand in the doorway. Please, come in—business is slow today anyway, so we might as well make the place lively.”

He spoke as he walked back into the antique shop. As soon as he went in, he saw Shirley craning her neck, peeking toward the outside. He casually rubbed the girl’s hair: “Calm down later.”

Shirley froze: “Calm down for wha—”

The next second, she knew why she had to calm down.

She saw the Inquisitor who stood at the very top of Pland’s Church when it came to force step inside. The “big sister” over one meter ninety tall walked past the little shorty under one meter sixty, and the pressure she brought was not only visual.

Shirley almost blurted out without thinking: “Wo—wow, you’re so tall!”

Vanna stopped without thinking and glanced at the girl standing nearby, whose expression was strange and whose whole body was tight. She nodded to her in a friendly way: “Hello.”

“Her name is Shirley,” Duncan said casually from the side. “She helps out in my shop. She was also there when the trouble at the City Museum happened. Miss Heidi should have mentioned her to you.”

“So you’re Shirley?” Vanna nodded, matching the description she had heard with the real person in front of her. “You really are a cute little girl.”

At this time, Nina, who had been reading by the counter, also heard the commotion. She ran over, and the first thing she saw was Vanna’s astonishing height. She recognized this famous Inquisitor at once and let out the same startled cry as Shirley.

“…This is why I don’t like going out with you,” Heidi finally could not help speaking up from behind Vanna, where Nina had not noticed her for a long time. “You just stand there and grab all the attention—I’m supposed to be the main character today, you know?”

“But I don’t want to attract attention this way either,” Vanna looked at her friend with a straight face. “I’ve already done my best to look ordinary today.”

“…Forget it, I’m used to it.” Heidi sighed, then greeted Nina and Shirley one by one. After that she took out the visiting gift she had brought and handed it to Duncan.

“I don’t know what you like, but I can’t come to thank you with empty hands. My father asked me to give this to you. He said someone as well-read as you, who is interested in history and occult studies, should like it.”

“You’re too polite. It was just a small favor at the time,” Duncan said in return as he reached out and took the gift. It was a wooden box that already looked quite old. He opened the lid right there, but when he saw what was inside, he became a little puzzled. “This is…?”

Inside was a book, a beautifully bound and expensive book, the kind respectable scholars in the Upper City would keep in their homes. On the hard dark purple cover, a line of elegant cursive letters read:

“City-States and Gods”

“This is a book from my father’s collection. It’s already very hard to find on the market now—its author was the great naturalist and theologian Mr. Maldano Victor from a century ago,” Heidi said with a smile. “It describes the historical changes of the Age of City-States and how various deity faiths, including the four True Gods, influenced civilized society. He said you should like things in this field.”

Duncan quietly looked at the exquisite book in the box, and a smile slowly appeared on his face.

“Of course, I really do like it. Please thank Old Mr. Morris for his kindness for me.”

After some polite words and a bit of friendly small talk—and since there were no other guests today anyway—Duncan simply closed the front door of the antique shop and treated the fairly spacious first floor as a sitting room.

Nina brought over two more chairs. Duncan brewed the best coffee in the shop for the two guests. Shirley pretended to straighten the shelves but actually just looked for a corner to lower her presence. Vanna looked around the small shop that seemed ordinary on the surface with some curiosity, while Heidi had already skillfully set her “medical box” on the counter. At the same time, she said to Nina: “Let’s get straight to the point. I heard you’ve been troubled by nightmares for a while, and often seem absent-minded?”

“Ah, they’re not really nightmares, just a strange dream that keeps going on…” Nina had not expected Miss Heidi to be so direct. She paused for a moment before answering. “I always dream that I’m standing somewhere very, very high, like on top of a tower. Then I see several blocks at my feet that have all been burned to ash. But nothing scary actually appears…”

“Stop,” Heidi raised a hand in a gesture, opening her medical box as she spoke casually. “Recurring scene, high place, fire, no specific frightening images, but the dream itself comes back so often that your mind can’t rest… Let me think…”

Nina leaned forward to peek into Heidi’s medical box. The first thing she saw inside were chisels, axes, saws, and all kinds of bottles and jars. She shrank her neck at once: “Um… Miss Heidi… can I not get treatment? I don’t think I’m that bad actually…”

Duncan also saw what was in Heidi’s medical box, and his eyebrow twitched: “Excuse me, but… are these really things you need for Mental Therapy?”

Was this elegant and gentle-looking physician in front of him actually a psychiatrist, or a vet?!

Chapter 141:

It turned out that in this world filled with strange things, the craft of “Mental Therapy” was much more hardcore than Duncan had imagined. It was so hardcore it no longer felt like a “technique” and was heading straight toward “industrial work”…

Luckily, that box of tools was not prepared for Nina. The psychiatrist lady noticed the horrified looks on the uncle and niece’s faces. She gave a smile that said she had seen this reaction many times before, then took a printed form from the very bottom of the box and handed it to Nina: “Fill this out roughly first.”

Nina let out a breath of relief at once: “I thought those… tools were for me.”

“These are for my work—when I work for the authority and the Church,” Heidi said with a small smile. “I often have to deal with dangerous people who are extremely stubborn and paranoid. Normal methods can’t pry open skulls that have been reinforced by Heretic thoughts.”

The more Duncan listened, the more he felt something was off. On the side, Shirley, who was trying hard to lower her presence but still could not help eavesdropping, shrank her neck even more. She quickly slipped to a spot farther away. While pretending to dust the shelves, she muttered through the mental link to Dog, who was in a hidden state: “So scary, so scary… this place is so scary… Mr. Duncan is already scary enough, and now there’s an Inquisitor here… and that Heidi too…”

Dog’s voice sounded in her mind, even more timid than she was: “How should I know?! Who would imagine you could get caught by a ghost captain while moving around on land, and then, while staying by that ghost captain’s side, you’d run into a Church Inquisitor coming over as a guest—are we the ones who’ve gone mad, or has the world gone mad? Would you believe it if someone told you this?”

While secretly watching what was going on by the counter, Shirley grumbled in her heart with a bitter face: [Who would believe that? If you told a fish it would one day die in a car crash, it wouldn’t believe it either…]

“…Don’t mention ‘fish’. I’m scared…”

Shirley paused: “Dog, when did you start being scared of fish?”

“And stop talking to me. Don’t let that Inquisitor notice anything—technically I’m in a hidden state right now, but when I’m near Mr. Duncan, I always feel like all my abilities work only half the time…”

Shirley hurriedly pulled back her thoughts and walked to the other end of the shelves. The people by the counter clearly did not put any attention on the unremarkable Shirley.

Nina looked at the form in front of her and found that it was full of very standard psychological test items. It was no different from the psychological forms she usually had to fill out before occult studies class at school or before visiting the City Museum. There were just more items, and a few questions that were not usually asked.

As she started filling it out, she asked curiously: “I heard before that your treatment methods are more professional. I thought you wouldn’t use the same kind of forms ordinary doctors use…”

“Forms are the basic step in psychological measurement. The difference between me and those half-trained people is that their diagnosis often ends once the form is done,” Heidi said with a smile. She took off the purple crystal pendant from her neck and played with it as she spoke. “My treatment only starts while you’re filling it out.”

Vanna’s gaze fell on Heidi’s crystal pendant without her noticing. She asked with some curiosity: “I keep seeing you wear this new pendant these two days… You seem to like it?”

Heidi paused, lowered her head to look at the pendant in her hand, as if she remembered something, then shook her head: “It’s just rare for my father to bring me a gift, that’s all. Ah, Vanna, did you know? This pendant was even ‘bought’ by my father from this shop.”

She put special stress on the word “bought”, as if she had to deny that the thing was just a free gift. Duncan, next to her, nodded with a gentle smile: “It really is a product of my shop—I hope this pendant has brought you good luck.”

Vanna could not help looking a couple more times at the “crystal” pendant that was obviously a fake. A sentence almost slipped out of her mouth: Even a famous scholar like Morris could fall for this?!

Luckily, she still cared about the feelings of Duncan, who was right there. That sentence circled around her windpipe once and then went back down into her lungs. At the same time, Nina quickly finished ticking off all the boxes on the form. She pushed the form to Heidi and said: “I’m done. Could you see if there’s any problem?”

“I already finished reading it while you were filling it out—including all the tiny details in your expressions and movements,” Heidi said directly as she put the paper away. “You have a psychological shadow that has been buried for many years, right? Have you had extra stress recently, making you think

of that shadow from time to time? In the last two days, your strange dreams have eased… Is it because the stress has disappeared, or has it shifted?”

Nina could not help widening her eyes, as if Heidi had hit some secret in her heart. Then she subconsciously glanced toward Duncan, a bit of hesitation on her face.

“We need a quiet and private place to do further mental relief and release,” Heidi said, looking up at Duncan. “Of course, first I need the consent of you, her Guardian, and also Miss Nina’s own cooperation.”

“Go upstairs,” Duncan nodded and looked at Nina. “Is that okay?”

“Okay.” Nina nodded very obediently, with no sign of refusal, though a trace of nervousness still showed in her eyes. That trace did not escape Heidi’s gaze.

“Don’t worry, Nina. It’s just a simple relaxation technique—you don’t really have any problem. You’re just a bit stressed and anxious,” Heidi said with a smile. A calming and trustworthy aura seemed to spread from that smile. Her voice was gentle, and the tension in Nina’s heart unknowingly faded away. At the same time she closed her medical box and set it aside. “I think we won’t even need any tools, incense, or medicine. I’ll just ask you a few questions.”

Only then did Nina completely relax. She nodded to Duncan, then led Heidi up the stairs to the second floor.

The sound of their two sets of footsteps slowly faded up the stairs.

Shirley still hid far away, focused on tidying the clutter in the corner.

At last, only Duncan and the Inquisitor sitting across from him were left by the counter.

Today was the first time Duncan had seen this Inquisitor face to face—the one who, by chance, had been left with the flame mark of the spirit form on her body. Right now, he could feel more and more clearly the mark left in Vanna's body, and he sensed that this originally extremely weak mark was slowly growing stronger because he was near.

Even without physical contact, that tiny spark still drew more power from the "source" and began to smolder and spread in Vanna's soul.

After noticing this, Duncan deliberately controlled the growth of that mark. He did not want this mark to be noticed by that unfathomable storm Goddess. If that happened, he would lose Vanna as this special "Node".

He was very curious about Vanna. Strictly speaking, he was interested in her identity as a priest, and in the faith behind her.

On the other hand, Vanna was also curiously observing this place and the "Mr. Duncan" sitting opposite her.

She had indeed come today to accompany Heidi and pay a visit of thanks, but there was another reason. There had been far too many suspicious points in that great fire at the City Museum.

In theory, that fire absolutely should not have gone out in such a short time, yet it had suddenly put itself out. In the blaze, Heidi had seen a projection that seemed like a fragment of the Sun. And Duncan, this ordinary person, had rushed into the fire to save people and brought the trapped ones out without a scratch. There was no solid evidence to connect these things, but her intuition told her she should come to this antique shop and take a look.

"Mr. Duncan," Vanna was the first to break the silence. She looked at Duncan with a calm face. "I have some questions about the great fire at the City Museum. May I ask them?"

“Of course,” Duncan nodded calmly. “I was there at the time, so I should be able to provide some information.”

“Thank you for your cooperation,” Vanna nodded slightly. “When you rushed in to save people, the fire at the City Museum was still burning then, right?”

“Yes,” Duncan nodded without hesitation. Because he did not know how much evidence this Inquisitor already had from the scene, he decided to tell the truth in parts where there might be proof. “The fire was huge at the time, especially in the corridor leading to the main exhibition hall. It was almost all burning.”

“But you all came out without a scratch,” Vanna asked next. “Can you tell me what happened after you went into the City Museum?”

Duncan put on a thinking look and pondered for two or three seconds before speaking, as if uncertain: “I also think it’s amazing that I could come out alive… But the fire inside the City Museum suddenly went down at that time. Can you imagine it? It wasn’t put out by the fire hoses outside, and it wasn’t because the fuel burned out. The fire just disappeared all at once. Even the smoke was gone…”

He clicked his tongue in wonder as he remembered, then finally raised his hand and gestured: “That must have been the Goddess’s blessing, right?”

As soon as he finished speaking, he heard a crash from Shirley’s side—she had accidentally knocked over a wooden carving in the corner.

“Careful!” he shouted at once, turning his head just like a real shopkeeper scolding his employee. “I already broke that thing’s base once. It’s glued back on now. Don’t knock it off again!”

“…The Goddess protects everyone in the city-state,” Vanna’s expression changed in a subtle way as she looked into Duncan’s eyes. “I can see that

you really are… an honest man.”

Duncan answered with a serious and open expression: “Of course. People like us who run an open shop live by not cheating anyone.”

Chapter 142: Inquiry and Treatment

Duncan looked completely sincere, with the kind of confidence that said: “If I open my doors to sell counterfeits, then I’ll at least let every sucker know exactly what they’re buying. If you can find a single real thing in my back room, I’ll give up the whole shop.” That calm, stubborn honesty clearly startled Vanna. She stared at him for a long moment before finally reacting: “Your honesty… really is impressive.”

“Do you have anything else you want to ask about that fire?” Duncan didn’t care about the odd tone in her voice. He asked calmly: “I heard afterward that The City Museum was sealed off that very day?”

“In fact, we strongly suspect that the fire at The City Museum involved supernatural influences.” Vanna did not hide this. Rumors of that kind had already spread through every street and alley, and the occult studies scholars at City Hall were publicly warning citizens not to go near the square in front of The City Museum for the time being. For the citizens of Pland, the existence of supernatural events did not need to be kept secret. Only the details and the truth behind them needed to be hidden. “The fire died down very quickly, far beyond what is normal… Mr. Duncan, please try to remember. After you went into The City Museum, you really didn’t see or hear anything unusual?”

“…No,” Duncan frowned. “In that situation, I didn’t have any attention left to spare on what was changing in the fire scene. I was just an ordinary

person, after all, not a trained Guardian."

He paused there, then raised his eyebrows: "Does the Church suspect that we few who escaped from the fire might be connected to the 'supernatural factor' behind it?"

"It's my personal suspicion," Vanna said seriously. "Please forgive me. Watching for any uncontrolled supernatural danger in the city-state is my duty as an Inquisitor. And I'm not saying you were the one who started the fire. supernatural power can stain an ordinary person, whether they meant it or not. I'm worried that all of you may have been passively dragged under the influence of some supernatural power during that fire. I'm worried for your safety."

"I understand." Duncan actually relaxed more than before. He really wasn't angry at all, because he could tell this Inquisitor was simply doing her job. "You've been observing here for quite a while. Have you found any clues?"

"…I really haven't found anything." Vanna shook her head. "There's no residual supernatural power here. The distribution of Shadows and the flow of aura inside and outside the whole building are completely normal. I think… you really were just ordinary persons swept into an supernatural incident."

Duncan thought for a moment and couldn't help adding: "Maybe… you could check again? What if there's some lingering supernatural power here that hasn't been found yet? Like you said, it's for our safety too…"

"I have confidence in my own judgment." Vanna lifted her chest a little before he could finish, and her tone grew firm. "By the Goddess's grace, my eyes are the most effective detection tools, especially in daylight. No Heretic power or Shadows from the deep layers can escape my sight—even the Eldritch Gods and Demons that are best at hiding have nowhere to run in front of me!"

She had barely finished speaking when another loud crash sounded not far away. Shirley had finally dropped the base of that wooden carving from earlier.

“I… I wanted to see if I could move it to a safer place…”

“Just leave that pile of things alone! If you’re bored, go wipe the windowsill!” Duncan said helplessly to Shirley, who was trying hard to play the shop assistant. Then he turned back to Vanna and, after struggling for a while, squeezed out: “…You’re right.”

“This child looks pretty clumsy.” Vanna glanced up at Shirley and spoke casually. “And she looks… a little nervous?”

“It’s her first day helping out,” Duncan said honestly. “She’s not an official shop assistant. She’s my niece’s friend. She came here to learn a few things and earn a bit of money for her family. Kids from the Lower City start working early.”

Vanna nodded. That sounded completely normal to her. After thinking for a moment, she turned her gaze back to Duncan: “There’s one more thing I want to confirm. After leaving The City Museum, did you have any lingering discomfort? Any nightmares?”

Duncan didn’t answer right away.

Someone had had nightmares. Shirley had not only had them; she had stood with him on the edge of a nightmare and seen impossible things. But that could not be said.

The Inquisitor in front of him was a “good person” who protected the city-state’s order, but in the eyes of the authority and the Church, Shirley was an out-and-out Heretic. In this world where everyone’s nerves were stretched tight, even the most fair and righteous Inquisitor would find it hard to show much tolerance or sympathy to a “Heretic” at a first meeting.

“No, everything has been normal.” Duncan shook his head. “But may I ask something? What kind of nightmare would it be? If something similar happens to us in the next few days, I want to recognize it quickly and go to the nearest Church for help.”

“It should be related to flames,” Vanna answered. “The scale is extremely large—flames violently erupting in the dark void, bending as they burst out and forming a magnificent arc. Considering you just escaped a fire with your lives, short-term trauma Shadows might also make you dream of something similar. Ordinary people can’t tell the difference between that kind of normal dream and a nightmare under supernatural influence. So I suggest that as long as you dream of flames, you should go to the nearest Cathedral at once.”

Duncan frowned.

Flames violently erupting in the dark void, forming a grand arc…

That didn’t sound like Nina’s dream. It wasn’t Shirley’s dream. It wasn’t like the ruins of the burned site he had seen last night either.

If he had to say, the serious look on Vanna’s face when she described that scene made him think, for no clear reason, of one thing… the Sun Fragment.

Only fragments of the Sun would have that kind of power and make an Inquisitor so solemn.

Duncan weighed it for a moment. Then, still staying inside the role of a “helpful citizen and ordinary person”, he carefully adjusted his wording and suddenly asked: “Let me ask something… Is this connected to those Suntists causing trouble in the city recently? Those cultists seem to spend all day on the Sun, flames, sacrificial rites and the like. It sounds like they’re ready to set the city on fire at any time.”

Everyone already knew there were Suntists active in the city and that the authority was hunting them, so even an ordinary person could have asked this question. Vanna clearly didn't overthink it. She nodded: "It's possible they were behind it… But it's enough for you to know that much. Don't dig any deeper. That's dangerous for ordinary persons."

As a high-ranking Inquisitor, Vanna knew that not long ago, a cultist stronghold in an abandoned factory had been reported and destroyed. She had even gone to the scene herself to investigate. But she didn't need to know all the details, so she naturally didn't realize that the "helpful citizen" who had reported that cultist nest was the antique shopkeeper standing in front of her.

Duncan also didn't mention his own report. From Vanna's answer, he had already vaguely confirmed his guess and fallen into deep thought.

Even the upper ranks of the Church believed this matter was tied to the Suntists. That meant it really had been a Sun Fragment. When the fire broke out at the City Museum, the influence of the Sun Fragment had truly appeared for a short time in the Mortal Realm and had alerted Vanna when she later went to handle the scene.

Then the "dream image" Vanna had described… could that actually be what the Sun Fragment looked like?!

A huge jet of flame, erupting fiercely in the dark void… That was nothing like what Duncan had pictured the first time he heard the name "Sun Fragment"!

In his first imagination, a "Sun Fragment" that cultists hunted for, and that could be sealed and kept asleep in a city-state, should have been something like an Anomaly—some physical object that had a vague link to the Sun, but in truth didn't have much to do with the real Sun. But if he went by Vanna's description…

Duncan tried hard to picture it. He thought back to his memories of the star called “the Sun” from his life on Earth, and more and more it felt like that thing… sounded exactly like a “solar prominence”!

From the scene alone, it was basically a solar prominence erupting into space!

His face did not change much, but inside his mind, his thoughts were surging—

Sun Fragments… so they were actually literal?!

At the same time, in Nina’s bedroom on the second floor, Heidi had already finished the usual questions and mental guidance for her “patient”.

She had more or less confirmed that Nina’s dreams were not ordinary nightmares, nor just recurring dreams caused by stress. But whether those dreams had been harmed by an supernatural influence still needed further judgment.

“We might need a short, gentle hypnosis session.” Heidi picked up the purple crystal pendant in her hand and spoke in a soft voice to the girl in front of her. “Don’t be nervous. Just follow my mental guidance and answer a few more questions.”

Chapter 143: hypnosis

Staring at the faintly swinging crystal pendant in Heidi's hand, Nina swallowed nervously. Even though Heidi had told her to relax, this was her first time receiving hypnosis treatment. It was hard for her to control her reaction.

While her gaze was drawn to the crystal pendant, she also noticed a simple-looking rune bead bracelet on Heidi's wrist. The bracelet was woven from tough silk cord and strung with many colorful stones. On a few of the stones she could see marks that looked like runes.

Noticing Nina's gaze, Heidi smiled and gave her wrist a little shake. "I'm a 'student' of the Truth Academy. I follow and serve God of Wisdom Rahm. You can't really tell from the outside, but on the official records, I'm actually a Cleric."

A Cleric… so she wasn't only a psychiatrist, but also a member of the Truth Academy?

Nina had of course heard of the Truth Academy. Its name sounded like a school, but its true form was one of the four Churches of the True Gods. Together with the Deep Sea Church, the Cult of Death, and the Flamebearer Church, it helped maintain the order of civilization in the Deep Sea era. Unlike the other three Churches, the Truth Academy didn't feel very "theological". It leaned more toward pure knowledge, and toward researching and spreading cutting-edge technology. Its believers built their relationships through master and student and through schools of thought.

Other Churches were rooted in Cathedrals and holy places, and their daily work was preaching faith and holding mass. The Truth Academy, however, had countless universities and laboratories in each city-state. When a higher-ranking priest met a lower-ranking priest, the usual greeting was to toss over a difficult problem and see if your faith in the Lord had reached a passing score. Its style was very strange.

Because the Truth Academy was so unusual, it actually had the fewest members among the four Churches of the True Gods. And among those members, the ones who had the right to wear its badge in daily life and be registered as official Clerics were even rarer—because the questions were truly hard.

Even in an ordinary university, they might not get more than a few top students in a whole year who were qualified to devote themselves to Rahm. That was even more distant from a poor child like Nina, who studied in a public school in the Lower City.

In Nina's eyes, Heidi suddenly seemed to be surrounded by a halo. That halo didn't relax her at all. It only made her more nervous.

It was the kind of awe a vocational school student felt when she saw the top graduate of a famous university.

Heidi, of course, noticed the change in Nina's expression, but she didn't mind. She played casually with the pendant in her hand and slowly began to speak, her tone as gentle as before: "Can you tell me about your childhood? Just now you said your parents died in an accident. That might be the Shadow in your heart… Can you tell me about it?"

"Actually… it's not something I can't talk about." Nina thought for a moment. "I've told a lot of people, but everyone says I was too young back then, that I don't remember clearly, that I'm just talking nonsense. Eleven years ago, there was a leak at a factory in the Sixth District. There were also

many cultists running around causing trouble. They arrested a lot of people later. Do you know about that?”

“Of course.” Heidi nodded. “I was only in my teens back then. When the accident happened, my family just happened to be staying near the Crossroad District. We saw the crowd charging past…”

“Then do you remember a big fire back then?”

“A fire?” Heidi tilted her head slightly and unconsciously stopped playing with the crystal pendant. “What fire?”

“See, you don’t know about that fire either. But in my memory, there’s always been a big fire. My parents died in that fire. But everyone says I remember it wrong…”

Heidi listened quietly to Nina’s story. After a long time, she nodded gently and asked: “So that should be the Shadow in your heart. You’re afraid of a fire that only you know existed. You’re afraid of when this strange thing will appear around you again and take away the people close to you, while no one can help you—and no one can even notice what you’re going through.”

Nina nodded lightly.

“Have you been under any pressure recently?” Heidi asked again. “With your studies, with daily life. These new pressures may be making the old gloom in your heart stronger…”

Nina stayed silent for a moment, then said hesitantly: “Maybe it’s because my uncle’s health was bad for a long time, and a while ago it got worse. That made me very worried…”

She paused there, then quickly added: “Ah, but he’s better now. I feel like I’ve relaxed a lot too. I haven’t had that strange dream in the last two days…”

“Worried about your family’s health…”

Heidi spoke softly, deep in thought. She listened to the girl’s murmurs, which sounded almost like sleep-talking, and watched Nina leaning against the headboard, half asleep. Then she casually put down the crystal pendant.

As a psychiatrist trained at the Truth Academy, and someone who had to deal with the supernatural, she didn’t need swinging pendants or burning vapors for hypnosis. A few sentences were enough.

The pendant’s only real use was to lock Nina’s gaze, help her relax, and lower her guard against words.

The young psychiatrist let out a quiet breath. Her eyes were gentle as she looked at Nina, who had completely relaxed, and watched her sink into deeper sleep.

“I can tell your life has been very hard,” she said softly. “You’ve buried all your tension and fear deep in your heart, and you’ve gotten used to living like this. You hope it will make things easier for the people around you, but you ignore yourself. But now you can relax. Sleep well. Leave all your pressure inside a dream that is about to fade. When you wake up, those worries will no longer belong to you.”

Half asleep, Nina’s voice sounded faintly: “…Thank you…”

Heidi smiled. To let Nina fall into an even deeper layer of relaxation, she asked casually, as if without thinking: “By the way, your uncle wasn’t well before, right? What illness did he have? Just now I saw Mr. Duncan and he looked quite healthy.”

This time Nina stayed silent much longer before whispering: “He was only weak, that’s all. Now… he’s completely better…”

However, Heidi no longer heard Nina’s answer.

At the very moment she asked that last question, she had already slumped over at the foot of Nina’s bed, falling into a sleep even deeper than her patient.

On Heidi’s right wrist, the hand-woven rune bead bracelet was glowing faintly. It was one of the badges believers of the Truth Academy often wore. It showed that the wearer was a Monk who had gone through strict training, received the care of God of Wisdom Rahm, and stood firm against the madness of Heretic powers. Every rune stone on it represented one of Rahm’s blessings.

After a few seconds of flickering, one red agate bead on the rune bead bracelet made a tiny cracking sound, then quickly crumbled into dust and drifted away.

Downstairs in the shop, Vanna asked Duncan a few more questions. On one hand, she wanted to know whether there were any details about the fire at The City Museum that had been missed. On the other, she wanted to confirm whether Duncan and the others had been influenced by the Sun Fragment.

As they talked, the strangeness and awkwardness of a first meeting slowly faded. The mood in the room grew warmer and more familiar.

Duncan could feel that this high-ranking Inquisitor of the Church truly cared about the safety of the survivors from that day’s fire. She wasn’t only doing it to strike at Heretics or to look for clues. Her concern was sincere, from the heart.

He didn’t know whether this young Inquisitor cared this much about every single person in the city-state, or if she was paying special attention to the people in this antique shop because of her connection to Heidi. But the sincerity Vanna showed now was enough for him to keep a good impression of her.

“Speaking of which, Miss Heidi and Nina have been upstairs for a while now, haven’t they?”

While they talked, Duncan thought of his niece and looked up at the stairs leading to the second floor.

“That’s true.” Reminded by him, Vanna reacted as well. She frowned slightly. “Normally Heidi’s treatment process is very quick…”

“…I don’t think you can use Miss Heidi’s usual treatment methods as the standard. Physical hypnosis and kinetic anesthesia are quick on anyone,” Duncan said, the corner of his mouth twitching. “But it is true that the two of them have been up there for too long… Do you think something happened?”

Vanna shook her head. “No. Heidi is a professional who trained strictly at the Truth Academy. She wouldn’t mess up a simple hypnosis session. Most likely she just started chatting with Nina. She can be like that sometimes—after dealing with stubborn cultists so often, she treats chatting with a normal person like a holiday. Let’s go up and take a look?”

“Let’s go up and take a look.”

Duncan and Vanna both stood and went to the second floor. One after the other, they walked to Nina’s bedroom door. Before they could push it open, they both heard sounds from inside—

Two alternating snores.

Chapter 144

“I’m very sorry, I’m very sorry, I don’t even know what happened…”

Heidi apologized with a face full of embarrassment. As a veteran psychiatrist, and a professional who had finished all her studies under the strict standards of the Truth Academy, her shame at this moment was hard to describe. Honestly, when Vanna had woken her up with that helpless look, Heidi had almost felt that her whole career was over…

At the same time, Nina had just woken up from her nap on the bed and looked completely confused. She had no idea what had happened. She only stared in a daze as Heidi apologized to her, then finally turned her eyes toward Duncan: “Uncle Duncan, what happened? Why did Miss Heidi…”

“The psychiatrist who was hypnotizing you was sleeping even more soundly than you were,” Duncan said helplessly. He sighed and pointed at the side of the bed. “She even drooled on the floor.”

His words were very blunt. As soon as he finished, Heidi could hardly lift her head.

In this awkward and messy mood, only Vanna still kept a serious face. She looked around the whole room at once, as if she were searching for or sensing something. At last her gaze fell on Heidi: “Are you really all right? Why did you fall asleep first during a hypnosis session?”

Hearing her friend’s serious tone, Heidi slowly came back to herself. She frowned and tried to recall carefully. After a moment she shook her head

slightly: “There’s nothing wrong with me. I must have been too tired lately, and after I finished the session I relaxed too much, so I drifted off.”

“You finished the session, then?” Vanna still did not seem reassured and asked again.

“Yes, it was finished.” Heidi thought it through once more, then nodded. “I asked Miss Nina a few questions. I only got drowsy and fell asleep after she answered.”

Duncan noticed how especially serious Vanna looked and could not help asking: “Is something wrong?”

“No… I’m just a little worried about Heidi,” Vanna said, shaking her head. “She has never had something like this happen before. But it’s probably just like she said. She’s too tired. She’s been working nonstop lately, and the rare day off she had was ruined by the fire at the City Museum.”

As soon as Nina heard that, she instinctively turned to Heidi and said: “Sorry. It looks like I took up the little free time you had…”

“No, no, you don’t need to apologize,” Heidi said quickly, waving her hand. “And if you look at it another way, I actually got a good nap here. I haven’t slept this soundly in a long time.”

After Vanna confirmed that there was indeed nothing abnormal about Heidi, she looked up at the sky outside the window. Then she stood and turned to Duncan: “It’s getting late. It looks like we should take our leave.”

“Don’t you need to rest a bit?” Duncan asked with the concern of the master of the house. “Miss Heidi still looks a little tired.”

“I’m much better already,” Heidi said with a small smile. “It’s not safe to stay out at night. I have to get home before the Sun goes down—my father worries about that a lot.”

Hearing that, Duncan did not say anything more. He helped Nina down from the bed, then looked at the two guests: “Then let me walk you downstairs.”

He escorted Heidi and Vanna to the front door on the first floor. By then, the Sun was already sinking toward the distant horizon.

Vanna went to start the car’s steam core. The strange steam machines of this world seemed to need almost no time to heat their boilers before starting. Duncan saw the dark gray car quickly give off the light hum of running machinery, while Heidi suddenly turned back before stepping out of the shop. She glanced at Nina beside her, and in the end her eyes fell on Duncan.

“I can see that you are a very responsible guardian now, but for a while before this you seemed to neglect Nina a little—and her tension and anxiety came from that,” Miss Psychiatrist said honestly and directly. “Of course, her condition is much better already, and after this session it will improve even more. But even the best treatment needs to be reinforced. The best healing for the mind still comes from a family’s care.”

[Nina’s tension and anxiety? And that earlier period… was before I took over this body?]

Duncan understood at once. He nodded to Heidi and thanked her sincerely: “Thank you for your help. I really wasn’t in a good state for a while before. That was my fault.”

“Actually, I should sit down and talk with you more carefully. Speaking with family after a session is also a very important part of the process, but we really don’t have time today,” Heidi said with a sigh as she took half a step back. “When I get home, I’ll sort out Nina’s condition again and write some follow-up suggestions in a letter for you.”

The two special guests finally said goodbye and left.

Watching that eye-catching car drive farther and farther down the street in the sunset of the Lower City, Duncan let out a small breath. His first face-to-face meeting with the Church's Inquisitor had been even more peaceful and smooth than he had expected.

After Vanna and Heidi left, Shirley finally crawled out of a corner on the first floor. The young lady stared nervously toward the door and only dared to come closer when she saw Duncan and Nina come back: "They really left?"

"They left, they left, relax," Duncan said, glancing at Shirley with a helpless tone. "You were hiding way too obviously. That actually makes people suspicious, you know? It's a good thing that Inquisitor didn't think too much about it."

"Of course I'm scared! That's an Inquisitor! The highest fighting force the Church has in the whole city-state!" Shirley's eyes went wide. She seemed afraid Duncan would not understand her worry and rushed to explain: "The highest-ranking clergy I usually meet are just the priest at the local Cathedral and the Guardians on patrol. And even then I have to duck out of their way—it's not like you don't know I have a mutt like Dog with me…"

She paused there and let out a sigh: "Ah, of course it's normal if you don't understand how I feel. To a being like you, the city's Inquisitors probably aren't much different from the priest at the local Cathedral…"

Nina looked at Shirley, then turned to glance in the direction where Vanna and Heidi had left. She frowned: "Shirley, someone like you… a 'wild supernatural'… would the Church really arrest you? You haven't done anything bad. Miss Heidi and Miss Vanna are both very nice people…"

“It has nothing to do with whether I do bad things or not,” Shirley said with a sigh. “The Church doesn’t arrest every wild supernatural, because in this world there are always some people who touch supernatural power for strange reasons. They aren’t all heretics, and the Church also allows a few free supernatural folk to live honestly among the common people—but they would definitely arrest me and Dog. By their standards, as long as you have anything to do with demons from the Abyssal Deep or Subspace, no matter what you are like right now, you are a potential heretic in the future.”

Nina frowned. This was a field she had never dealt with before, and Shirley’s words made her feel a little torn. But Duncan quickly broke through her thoughts: “Nina, how are you feeling now?”

“Me? I’m fine,” Nina answered at once. “I think Miss Heidi’s ‘treatment’ worked pretty well. I talked with her for a while and took a little nap. I feel much more relaxed!”

“Really? That’s good.”

Duncan nodded lightly and did not say anything more. He started walking toward the stairs. Only then did Shirley seem to suddenly react. She looked at the sky outside and could not help letting out a cry of despair: “Ah, I was planning to go home today…”

“You can just think about it,” Duncan said without turning his head. “Take a look at the sky outside. Are you really planning to spend the night playing cat and mouse with the Church’s Guardians?”

Nina also laughed. She stepped forward and patted Shirley on the shoulder: “Just stay here with peace of mind. You can keep me company and chat with me before bed—going home can wait until tomorrow!”

…

On the way back to the Upper City, Vanna held the steering wheel, and Heidi sat in the passenger seat beside her, yawning.

“Yaaawn… That nap felt really good…” Heidi yawned again and asked casually: “So, what did you talk about with that antique shopkeeper? Did you notice anything wrong?”

“No anomalies at all,” Vanna answered while watching the road ahead. “That shopkeeper was just an ordinary person, and so was that young lady named Shirley. There were no signs that the whole antique shop had been touched by any supernatural power or evil will. They really should have just escaped by luck. And you? Did you notice anything while dealing with Nina?”

“Everything was normal,” Heidi said with a nod. She raised her hand and touched the crystal pendant that she had put back on her chest. The rune bead bracelet on her wrist, which represented the Truth Academy, slid down a little. One bead in the circle was already missing, but she did not notice it at all. “But Nina did mention something during the hypnosis. It was a bit strange.”

“Strange? What was it?”

“She mentioned that she had been caught in a big fire when she was little, the fire during that factory leak incident eleven years ago,” Heidi said offhandedly. “But you know, eleven years ago there wasn’t any…”

She had only said half of it when a sudden squeal of brakes and the shaking of the car cut her off. Vanna brought the car to a sharp stop and stared wide-eyed at her friend: “A big fire?! Nina said she remembered a fire eleven years ago?”

“Yes,” Heidi said, a little dazed. “Why are you reacting so strongly?”

Vanna did not speak for a moment. Her face changed twice in quick succession. From her reaction, Heidi sensed that something was wrong: “Should we turn around right now? We can go back and ask her properly…”

“No.” After thinking for a moment, Vanna suddenly shook her head, then turned her attention back to the road ahead.

The car started moving again. Under the ever-dimming sky, the scenery of the streets on both sides began to slide backward faster and faster.

Heidi looked at her friend in the driver’s seat, worried and puzzled. She seemed about to ask something, but before she could speak, Vanna shook her head slightly.

“I know you’re confused, but don’t ask for now. Until I’ve confirmed a few things, don’t mention this to anyone else.”

She paused there, then spoke again in a low voice, almost to herself: “Maybe… we came a bit too hastily today.”

Chapter 145

Heidi wisely did not keep asking.

She knew that she and Vanna were different. In name, she was also a member of the clergy and even held official certification from the Truth Academy. But compared with facing those dangerous hidden powers head-on, she was actually better at pure research and thinking. She could pry secrets out of cultists' minds and pick out the shadows that heretics left behind in the whispers of a collective hallucination, but that was completely different from the work of an Inquisitor.

She herself lacked sensitivity to certain threats.

But Vanna had spent years fighting heretics and hidden powers head-on. She might already have sensed some kind of shadow. Their trip to the Lower City today had probably brushed against something by accident.

When they were almost home, Heidi asked a question: "Was there something wrong with that antique shop?"

"The antique shop was completely normal," Vanna said as she slowed the car, a thoughtful look on her face. "But in our city-state… something might not be normal."

The sky was completely dark now. The bell that marked the change from day to night and the whistle from the central steam core sounded at the same time, cutting through the clouds above the city in the fading sunset. In the Upper City, the gas lamps along the streets had already been lit half an

hour earlier. Heidi reached her front door, hearing the sound of the car behind her fade into the distance.

At night, the city went under curfew, but the order only applied to ordinary people who lacked the power to protect themselves. The Church's Inquisitors were clearly not affected. Before Vanna returned to the great Cathedral, she still had to swing by the City Museum to inspect the place and meet with the Guardians in charge of sealing off the scene. Her rest days were often like this—she never really rested.

Heidi could not help thinking again of her own ruined day off. She sighed and opened the door to go inside.

Lights were on in the spacious living room, but no one was in sight. The house was quiet everywhere. The daytime maid they hired to handle cleaning and laundry had gone home before the Sun went down, so this huge house felt a bit empty.

But Heidi was long used to it. Her father was the sort of man who, once he went into his study, could not be dragged out easily. Her mother's health was poor, and she often rested in the bedroom. For this family of three, the house was a bit too large, and most of the time it was this quiet.

But that did not mean the house lacked warmth. Heidi had a very good relationship with her parents. It had always been good.

She smoothly took off her coat, put away her hat and medical bag, and glanced at the study with its light still on. She did not disturb her father, who was probably buried in his books, but went as usual to her parents' bedroom and knocked on the door: "I'm home—are you in there?"

Her mother's voice came from inside, carrying helplessness and a bit of pretend anger: "You're getting home this late!"

Heidi stuck out her tongue at the door and quickly smoothed her expression. Then she pushed the door open with a smile, muttering as she went in: “I went out with Vanna. You really don’t have to worry. She could beat up the whole city with one hand…”

The light in the room was quite dim, because anything too bright would irritate her mother’s eyes. Her mother had been hurt by chemical fumes in the factory leak accident eleven years ago, and her eyes had never been right since.

Heidi let her eyes adjust to the dim light and saw her mother leaning against the headboard. She was a kindly old lady in soft pajamas, working by touch on a knotted craft that was unique to the city-state of Pland. In the shifting shadows of the dim lamp, she looked up at Heidi and spoke with a hint of helplessness: “Just keep running around with Vanna every day. Sooner or later you’ll end up like her, unable to find a husband. I know for a fact that she sneaks off to the marriage help center every weekend, picks someone there, and beats him up. The Cathedral gets complaints about her every single day…”

Heidi’s expression turned a bit odd at once: “Uh… please don’t say that… Vanna is an Inquisitor now…”

“So what if she’s an Inquisitor? She still ate lunch at our house for years,” the old lady grumbled, her hands still moving quickly. “If you ask me, that child turned out this way because of her uncle’s upbringing. Her mind is strangely stubborn. At her baptism she just had to swear these vows. Swear if you want, but she took all Three Great Vows at once. Normal nuns pick just one. She insisted on all three to prove how devout she was, and now she’s trapped herself and can’t get married at all…”

Listening to her mother’s endless chatter, Heidi could only smile awkwardly. She finally waited until the old lady paused for breath halfway

through and quickly seized the chance to change the subject, looking at the craft in her mother's hands: "Are you almost done weaving it?"

"I wove it and took it apart, over and over, and now I'm finally a little satisfied," her mother said with a smile, holding up a ribbon of silk that looked like a colorful sash. The fine silk cords were woven with special techniques, leaving intricate open patterns and studded with pretty stones and beads. It was a kind of handiwork unique to the city-state of Pland, very complex and time-consuming. People believed it brought blessings and drove away evil. "I wonder if by the time it's finished you will have found a good young man…"

Heidi glanced at the almost finished knotwork sash and ventured a cautious suggestion: "Then maybe… you could take it apart one more time. It might still be in time…"

"You're just trying to make me angry!"

Heidi quickly smiled along and slipped out of the room.

Her mother's muttering followed her from behind as Heidi shut the door. She tiptoed toward the kitchen, but as soon as she started to walk, she saw her father standing in the hallway.

The refined, gray-haired Morris looked helplessly at his sneaky daughter: "I heard you come home a while ago… Did you get your mother worked up again?"

Heidi waved her hands quickly: "No, no, we were just chatting."

"Did you give the gift to Mr. Duncan?" Morris asked.

"I did—Mr. Duncan was very happy," Heidi said, nodding. Then she could not help looking at her father a few times. "But I really didn't expect you to be willing to give away one of your favorite books…"

“That was only a collectible—but he saved your life,” Morris said calmly. “In fact, I don’t think it is enough. In a few days we should pay him another visit to thank him properly.”

Heidi suddenly remembered her little ‘mistake’ during Nina’s hypnosis session today, and her expression turned a bit awkward: “We don’t have to… be that formal, do we?”

“It’s not about formality. Mr. Duncan saved your life, and I’m not just your father, I’m also Nina’s teacher. Besides, Mr. Duncan is an antique dealer with a strong thirst for knowledge and a real eagerness to learn. From a social point of view, this is a relationship worth cultivating,” Morris explained casually. “I like a word that Mr. Duncan often uses. He calls it a kind of ‘fate’…”

“All right, all right, your thinking makes sense, it makes sense,” Heidi said, feeling a headache the moment her father—who was not even good at socializing himself—started trying to teach her social etiquette again. “Then go visit him next time if you want, but please don’t buy random things again, okay…”

“That depends on whether any collectibles appear that can catch my eye,” Morris said offhandedly. Then he thought for a moment and asked, as if casually: “You went with Vanna today, right?”

“Yeah. She happened to have a day off today, so I rode in her car.”

Morris thought for a bit more, looking a little hesitant: “It feels like… you and Vanna are very close.”

“I’ve always been very close to her,” Heidi said, feeling a bit baffled. “We’ve known each other since we were little…”

“No, I just think…” The old gentleman suddenly began to stammer a little. He did not even know why, but right then he suddenly remembered

something Mr. Duncan had said to him during their last visit to the antique shop:

“A girls’ school is fine too…”

“Father?” Heidi looked at her father’s strange expression and could not help calling out.

“Ah, it’s nothing.” Morris snapped out of it, feeling that his thoughts just now had been a bit too wild. He hurried to pull himself together and tried to change the subject so his daughter would not notice. As his eyes shifted, his gaze suddenly fell on Heidi’s wrist.

The bracelet that represented the protection of the God of Wisdom Rahm was missing a red agate bead.

The old man’s expression changed sharply, but then he noticed how completely normal Heidi looked. He forced himself to get his emotions under control, calming down as he spoke in a seemingly casual tone: “Did you lose a bead on your bracelet? Did you knock it off by accident?”

“Bracelet?” Heidi froze for a second and raised her wrist to look. She saw the empty place in the string, but her expression was perfectly natural: “Hasn’t there always been one missing here?”

Always been one missing?

Morris slowly brought his breathing and heartbeat under control, and also tried to steady his feelings and his flow of thoughts, as if afraid that thinking too intensely might draw some dangerous gaze. At the same time he began to remember, to recall what the bracelet on his daughter’s wrist had looked like the last time he saw it.

After two seconds, he finished stabilizing and shielding his own thoughts. Only then did he ease his expression and ask in his usual tone, as if casually: “By the way, you only went to that antique shop today, right?”

Chapter 146: Ashes

Heidi did not notice anything strange in her father's tone.

"Yeah," she nodded calmly and said: "I just went to Mr. Duncan's antique shop with Vanna. I chatted with Mr. Duncan for a bit, then gave Nina a hypnosis treatment, and after that I came back with Vanna."

When she reached the end, she hesitated for a moment. She wondered whether she should tell her father about what she had heard from Nina about the fire, and about Vanna's strange reaction after hearing it. In the end, she still pushed that thought down.

She remembered Vanna's unusually serious expression in the carriage very clearly. This matter might involve dangerous hidden powers, and it might already be serious enough that just speaking of it could draw some prying gaze. Her father, like her, served God of Wisdom Rahm as a Truth believer and could barely be counted as half an supernatural, but like most Truth Believers, he was closer to a pure scholar and was not good at dealing directly with dangerous things.

Morris kept his gentle, calm expression. He nodded lightly and said, as if in passing: "You stayed there quite a while… Did you forget the time while chatting with Mr. Duncan? He really is a very curious man."

"Uh… not really," Heidi looked a bit embarrassed at once. "It's just… I lost some time while giving Nina the hypnosis treatment."

"During Nina's hypnosis?" Morris raised his eyebrows when he heard his student's name. "It didn't go well? Is her mental state very bad? Was she

affected by that fire at the City Museum?”

Heidi almost wanted to roll her eyes at this string of questions from her father: “You really do care about your student, huh—relax, she’s fine. She was only a bit anxious to begin with. After my relaxation and guidance, she’s completely okay now. It won’t affect her final exams. When I said it delayed me… I meant something else.”

Morris made a curious sound: “Oh?”

“Ahaha, I’ve probably just been a bit too tired lately,” Heidi gave two awkward dry laughs. “After I hypnotized her, I fell asleep myself, and slept straight until evening…”

“You fell asleep yourself while you were hypnotizing Nina?” Morris’s expression finally changed a little, but he quickly brought it back under control. “That’s not like you.”

“People slip up sometimes, and I haven’t had a vacation in ages,” Heidi waved impatiently. “Come on, stop asking. I’m already an adult, but if I come home a little late, you and Mother both get this tense and throw questions at me one after another…”

Morris only looked quietly at his daughter for a few seconds. Then his face showed the same gentle look as always, and he shook his head with a smile: “Alright, then I won’t ask. There’s food in the kitchen. Just heat it up a bit. I’ll go check on your mother.”

“Okay.” Heidi nodded. After saying goodbye to her father, she headed toward the kitchen. But after only a few steps, she suddenly turned back. “Oh, right, you still plan to go visit that antique shop again later, don’t you?”

“Yes,” Morris was already standing at the bedroom door. The wall lamp on the corridor wall beside him cast a dim yellow light, spilling mottled

shadows across his aging face. “Is something the matter?”

“I left in a hurry today, so I didn’t have a proper talk with Mr. Duncan about Nina’s situation. I’ll write him a letter later. When you go over, you can take it with you.”

“No problem,” Morris nodded. Then, as if speaking more to himself, he muttered softly: “I really do have to go again…”

Heidi left, but the old historian with graying hair still stood quietly at the bedroom door. He seemed to be deep in thought. After nearly ten seconds, he finally let out a soft breath and pushed open the dark wooden door.

The light in the bedroom was still dim. In the tastefully decorated room, only a small wall lamp was lit. The yellow light fell down, faintly outlining the shape on the bed.

Morris turned and carefully locked the door, then slowly walked to the bedside.

“Dear, are you alright?”

He spoke softly to the heap of writhing ashes on the bed that still kept a human outline.

From that pile of ashes, which had a blurred human shape and drifted and writhed without stopping, there came a faint whispering sound, as if answering him gently. Among the ashes, the almost-finished knotwork sash made a light rustling sound. Bright silk cords, pulled by the ashes, slowly threaded back and forth, weaving one knot after another, slow yet steady.

“Yes, it’s really beautiful. Your handiwork has always been good,” Morris heard the reply in that faint whisper. He smiled, praising his wife’s weaving as he said: “I still have the one you made for me hanging in my study.”

The room fell quiet. In the dim light, time itself seemed tricked into freezing at this moment. But after half a minute, Morris still broke the silence: “Heidi went out today. When she came back, one red agate bead on her bracelet was gone.”

The ashes on the bed suddenly went still and let out a low murmur.

“I still don’t know exactly what happened,” Morris spoke slowly. “If that was one of our Lord Rahm’s protections taking effect, it means Heidi ran into a danger today that was strong enough to pierce her rational defenses. But Heidi herself doesn’t know anything. I didn’t sense any malicious intent on her either. It looks more like she brushed past ‘something’ without knowing, and passively triggered the bracelet’s protection…”

Morris suddenly stopped and performed a Listening Rite, tilting his head toward the faint murmurs coming from the ashes.

“Yes, after I reminded her, Heidi noticed the missing part of the bracelet. That’s the problem—she believes that red agate bead never existed in the first place,” Morris nodded. “This is a kind of self?protection. It might come from her own intuition, or it might come from the ‘enlightenment’ of the God of Wisdom. But either way, this protection is stopping her from learning more about certain things…

“As for me? I want to go investigate. I’ll go by myself.”

The pile of ashes on the bed rose and fell slightly.

Morris shook his head. “There may be some risk, so I’ll do prayer and divination in advance. But I must go. I’ve actually been to that place once. It only looked like an ordinary antique shop. A diligent shopkeeper and a studious child lived there. I didn’t sense any malice or evil power lurking in it at the time…

“So if the dangerous factor only appeared in that shop today when Heidi visited, then the master of that shop might also be under threat. My student lives there, so I have to go see.

“After all, I am her teacher, and also a Servitor of the God of Wisdom…”

Morris spoke softly. Then he heard faint whispers from the ashes on the bed again. He tilted his head, listening with the Listening rite for a long time, before slowly shaking his head.

“No. We can’t alarm the people at the Cathedral… They might handle it more effectively, but their overly forceful style could also put my student in danger. For the Church’s Guardians, suppressing heresy and wiping out evil always comes first. And…”

Morris paused and let out a quiet sigh before he went on: “And honestly, I don’t really want to draw the Cathedral’s attention. After all… I am a man whose faith has already wavered, and who hides a heretic.”

His voice grew low. His eyes, carrying the power of gaze, rested gently on the pile of ashes on the bed—rested on his wife, who had already died in a great fire eleven years ago.

Rested on the shadow she had left in the mortal world.

The ashes slowly rose. A stream of ash seemed to gather into the shape of an arm and lightly brushed across Morris’s face.

“I know… I know…” Morris lowered his head, as if talking to himself, yet also as if confessing to some unseen presence. “I am someone whose faith has wavered, and I’m too cowardly to fall completely. The God of Wisdom gave me eyes that could see through falsehood that day, but I weakly closed them and made an unrealistic wish. I wanted to keep you in this world, yet I couldn’t completely lie to myself… and instead, I trapped myself in this most awkward state…”

He raised his head and lightly closed his hand around that drifting strand of ash, but his fingers passed straight through the dust.

“I really wish I were as ignorant as Heidi. Then I could see your other form clearly… I haven’t seen you for eleven years.”

A soft sound came from the ashes, like sand rubbing together, or like a small, warm fire crackling. Morris listened to the sound, and his heart slowly calmed down.

“I understand, I understand… This will all end. Every stage has its curtain call. No matter what answered my wish that day, one day it will come to claim its destined price. I’ve actually been ready for a long time. When it comes to take that price, I will make myself disappear from this world, cleanly and completely. Not even the shadows of Subspace will be allowed to use this one ‘wish’ to reach into the Mortal Realm. But…”

Morris raised his head and fixed his gaze on the outline of ashes in the dim light.

“But before that day comes… stay with me a little longer.”

Chapter 147: Appearing in the Mortal Realm?

“Uncle Duncan, I’m off to school!”

With a cheerful shout, Nina thumped down the stairs. She turned and waved toward the second floor, then ran toward the front door.

The rest day was over. It was a school day again.

But before she reached the door, Nina suddenly stopped. She saw a figure moving behind a shelf not far ahead—the figure stepped out. It was Shirley.

“Ah, Shirley,” Nina stopped happily and waved at the girl in front of her. “I was wondering where you went—want to walk together?”

“Together?” Shirley blinked in confusion. “Together where?”

“To school, today is…” Nina spoke without thinking, but halfway through she realized, and her face turned a bit awkward. “Ah, sorry, I forgot…”

Shirley was not her classmate and did not go to school. The pleasant time they had spent together on campus had only been a play. Nina knew that, but it had still truly happened, and many times she still forgot.

Shirley’s expression also turned strange for a moment, and there was apology in her eyes. But she quickly pulled herself together and shook her head lightly: “I won’t be going with you. My… ‘investigation’ at that school is already finished.”

“Yeah, that’s true,” Nina pressed her lips together, then soon went back to her usual bright smile. “Sorry, I forgot. Then I’ll head out first, okay?”

“Mm,” Shirley nodded, then as if suddenly remembering something, added: “Oh, Nina, I… I’m going home today.”

“Going home?” Nina froze. In just two days, she had already taken it for granted that Shirley was one of the people who belonged here, so when the other girl mentioned going home, she couldn’t react for a moment. “You’re not staying here anymore?”

“I have to go home. I was only staying here for a while,” Shirley waved her hands as she finally said something she had wanted to say for a long time. “I already talked to Mr. Duncan. He agreed.”

Nina did not say anything for a while and only stared blankly. After several seconds, she finally asked in a hesitant voice: “Then… then will you come back later?”

If she could help it, she really never wanted to come back here again. She even wanted to steal a boat ticket and run off to Frostholm to lie low.

That heartfelt desire to run flashed through Shirley’s mind for a second, but then she suddenly felt as if a gaze had passed through the second?floor floorboards and fallen right on her. She hurriedly shrank her neck without thinking. “I… I’ll come visit you when I have the chance. My home isn’t that far away anyway. Ha, haha…”

Nina tilted her head. For some reason, she felt that Shirley’s reaction just now had been a bit odd. But she soon stopped thinking about it. She was happy again because of the promise that Shirley would “come find her when she had the chance,” and that was enough. So she waved cheerfully, then turned and ran out the door like a gust of wind, disappearing into the street outside the antique shop.

Shirley stared blankly as Nina ran off like the wind. After a moment, she shivered and suddenly came back to herself, realizing that a figure was standing on the stairs not far away, calmly watching her.

She quickly turned around and bent in a bow with a level of politeness she rarely showed in her life. “M?Mr. Duncan, good morning!”

“You’re much more polite now. This is how a girl your age should act,” Duncan said lightly as he walked down the stairs. “Did you explain everything clearly to Nina? You’re going home today?”

“I… I did explain it,” Shirley kept her head down. She didn’t even dare to raise her voice, afraid that the big boss would get annoyed and go back on his word. “And you agreed that I can leave today.”

“Why are you nervous again? You were fine yesterday. Does your nervousness reset every morning?” Duncan shook his head, half amused and half helpless. He stepped forward and patted Shirley’s rather thin shoulder. “Relax a bit. I never said I would lock you up somewhere. I only invited you to stay here as a guest for two days. When you want to go back, you can go back. When you want to come, you can come anytime.”

“I… I understand,” Shirley nodded again and again, then added helplessly, “A?actually, I’m not that nervous. It’s Dog that keeps getting nervous. Whenever you get close, it gets nervous on instinct, and then that nervous feeling spreads to me.”

“Dog, huh… Well, that can’t be helped. Its nerves seem to come from the sharp senses of Abyssal demons,” Duncan shrugged, then looked at Shirley again. “But are you really not going to think about it? You could stay here. The place you and Dog live in seems a bit shabby, and it’s not very safe after nightfall. Compared to that, this is a very safe place.”

A Shadow of Subspace calling his own lair a safe place—those words were both reasonable and ridiculous at the same time. Shirley thought it over for a long while and still couldn't find any point to argue with (and mainly, she didn't have the nerve to argue). In the end, she could only let out a silly laugh: "Ah… ahaha… um…"

"Forget it, I was just saying. Don't get hung up on it," Duncan saw her reaction and knew how it was. He waved a hand. "If you want to go, then go. You already know how to contact me now. If you discover any new clues about those Suntists, remember to call me anytime."

Shirley nodded silently.

After these two dreamlike days, she finally had permission to leave this place. She had been given the chance to get away from this terrifying being. But when the chance truly appeared… she suddenly found she didn't quite know what to do.

Chatting and joking with a "friend." Living under the care of an "elder." A warm bedroom, bright lights, good food, and a peaceful life without fearing nightmares or hiding from Guardians.

Now, she was allowed to leave.

For some reason, an absurd thought rose in Shirley's mind—

A bright world had opened its doors to her for a brief time. Now, those doors were about to close.

Not long ago, this had been what she dreamed of—honestly, it still was. She was just… a little conflicted.

Through the mental link, she suddenly heard Dog's low mutter: "Our life is going back on track, Shirley."

"Yeah, it's going back on track."

Shirley murmured softly in her mind. Then she raised her head, wanting to say goodbye to Mr. Duncan.

But just then, Duncan’s expression suddenly changed a little.

In some unseen way, he sensed a presence flash by in the distance. That presence… was one of the Marks he had left behind!

“Mr. Duncan?” Shirley noticed how his face suddenly grew serious and immediately tensed up. “You…”

“I sensed a presence,” Duncan said softly, not waiting for her to finish. He lifted his head and looked into the distance. “It seems to be coming from that direction.”

Shirley did not understand at first. “A presence?”

“It’s the little flame I left on that ‘little bug’,” Duncan lowered his head slightly and fixed his gaze on Shirley’s eyes. “Do you remember the Umbrella Fiend that attacked you at the edge of the dream?”

Shirley froze for a second, then her eyes went wide. “The fragment you let ‘go home’? But… but that was in the dreamscape…”

“Yes, that attacker appeared in the dreamscape,” Duncan’s tone grew meaningful. “But now I’ve sensed that mark in the Mortal Realm.”

Shirley stared, wide?eyed. She suddenly remembered what Mr. Duncan had said to her in that nightmare—

Maybe, that was not just a dream.

“Shirley,” Duncan’s voice suddenly came, cutting off the girl’s thoughts. He lowered his head a bit, a smile on his face. “Before you go home, want to come investigate with me again? Of course, if you don’t—”

“I want to go!” Shirley answered at once before he could finish, her attitude so firm that she even scared herself. Then, as if to smooth over the awkwardness, she quickly added, “Th?that ‘thing’ appeared on the street after the great fire. It must be connected to that fire back then…”

Duncan pressed down on Shirley’s shoulder. “Then we’ll go together.”

“How are we going?” Shirley drew a slow breath. “You can pinpoint where that thing is, right? Are we taking the bus again like last time…”

Duncan shook his head with a smile. “Now I have a more convenient way to travel.”

Shirley blinked in surprise and was just about to ask what this more convenient way was when, out of the corner of her eye, she suddenly saw a shadow swoop down from the second?floor stair landing. At the same time, a string of sharp, strange female cries rang out: “Twin Immortals Bridge, via Chenghua Avenue… seats! Seats in the back… sunflower seeds, drinks, mineral water! Feet in, both sides, pull your feet in!”

The sudden darting shadow and the sudden shout both startled Shirley. When she finally saw what it was, her eyes went even wider than before: it was that weird pigeon! The one that could eat almost its own body’s worth of fries in a single meal!

The next second, under Shirley’s dumbfounded gaze, AI had already swept in a fast circle through the air. emerald flame burst up around it. A moment ago it had been just a chubby, harmless?looking white dove, but in the blink of an eye it turned into a terrifying skeletal dove in spirit form.

Shirley: “…?!”

Her neck stiff, she slowly turned her head, wanting to confirm something with Duncan. But before she could speak, her vision suddenly blurred…

Amid AI’s nonstop chatter of “Seats, seats in the back,” a vortex like a doorway of flame flashed into being. The next second, a swift white dove shot out of the antique shop and flew straight into the distance.

Chapter 148

A swift white blur swept over the old, filthy alleys of the Lower City, over the crisscrossing pipes and relief vents above the factories, over a desolate station and its empty streets, and finally darted into a narrow, shabby alley.

ghostly green flame suddenly blossomed, spreading through the air like a doorway. The vortex within that blazing gate pulsed once, and Duncan stepped out.

Shirley, still a little dazed, followed right behind him.

Duncan looked back at the girl behind him, gave her a quick once-over, and finally asked in a low voice: “How do you feel? Anything uncomfortable?”

“I… I’m okay,” Shirley said. She was still dizzy, but the dizziness came more from suddenly being dragged through the air by the big boss than from any real physical discomfort. She glanced up at AI, who had reverted to a white dove and was perched on Duncan’s shoulder. After a long moment, she used the mental link to speak with Dog, who was in his hidden state, hiding inside her soul: “Dog, can you beat that dove?”

“…Don’t even ask. If you ask, the answer is no,” Dog replied, sounding sullen. “Forget the bird the big boss keeps. I couldn’t even beat the fish the big boss stews…”

Shirley froze. “Why are you suddenly talking about fish?”

“Because I’ve figured it out. Anything near that being probably stops obeying normal rules…”

Duncan had no idea Shirley was muttering with Dog. He only checked Shirley again with his own eyes, then felt the feedback from the mark he had left on her, and finally relaxed completely.

In truth, he was quite confident in AI's ability to transport living people. Not only because he had already tested it on his current mortal body, but also because afterward he had AI perform a lot of "live tests" outside, using all kinds of birds, beasts, and other small animals. Every test had gone perfectly, proving that this pigeon could carry living targets without harm—yet even with so many trials, he still instinctively checked on Shirley again.

After all, AI was full of mysteries. No one knew how many strange traits it still hid, waiting to be discovered. Being a little more careful when using the "Bone Dove Express" never hurt.

Once he finished checking on Shirley, he turned his attention to the surroundings.

In front of him lay a cold, deserted alley. At the far end he could faintly see the crumbling street beyond. Old, poorly maintained pipes stretched overhead between the houses on both sides, and at some joints thin streams of steam hissed out.

It was the kind of scene common in many parts of the Lower City.

But Shirley still recognized where they were at a glance.

"This is… the Sixth District?" Her eyes widened in surprise. "Mr. Duncan, was this where you sensed that mark appear?"

"That's right, the Sixth District. We've come back here again, but…" Duncan let out a breath, then frowned slightly. "The mark's signal faded about a minute ago."

"…Faded? Did it go out?"

Shirley asked in shock, but Duncan did not answer. He only stared thoughtfully in a certain direction.

In Shirley's "dream", he had planted a tiny flame into the fragment left behind when the attacker split apart. He had ordered that fragment to return to its "main body". Not long after, when Shirley's dream ended, he lost his sense of that flame. Only just now had that mark suddenly reappeared in his perception, guiding him here.

Here, to the Sixth District in the Mortal Realm.

The spirit form fire that should have spread only within the dream had suddenly sent a signal back from the Mortal Realm. Shirley's own dream, at its edges, had linked to the sights in Nina's dream. The umbrella-wielding monster that attacked Shirley in the nightmare had once appeared at the great fire at the City Museum in the Mortal Realm…

Without realizing it, many clues that seemed to contradict each other yet faintly connected were lining up in Duncan's mind. He felt as if he were about to touch that unseen Veil.

Or rather, even though that vast Veil covered the whole city, it still had a "gap" somewhere. That gap was in the Sixth District—at some place he and Shirley had overlooked last time.

He was looking toward the spot where he had last sensed the mark's "signal".

The mark's trace had appeared only briefly, then faded quickly a minute ago. But Duncan did not believe the flame he left behind had gone out. Even if he could no longer fix its location, he could still sense that little fire burning on, and that it had grown far stronger than before.

Since the flame was still burning and growing, that meant its "mission" was not over yet. It was still chasing, devouring, and assimilating that attacker,

maybe even spreading into a roaring blaze. The way it flickered into the Sixth District for a moment and then vanished again might mean the Veil here was unstable, with a gap that opened and closed for a short time and let the two layers of the world overlap and connect.

He had to find that gap—the gap that seemed to link the dream and the Mortal Realm.

Several days later, Duncan once again led Shirley through the bleak, run-down streets of the Sixth District. This time they did not waste time asking the locals anything. They headed straight for the deepest part of the neighborhood.

“The abandoned factory is the other way…” On the way, Shirley raised an arm and pointed at a large building in the distance.

“We are not going to that factory,” Duncan said quickly. “We’re going this way.”

“Oh…”

Shirley answered softly, then hurried her short legs to keep up with Duncan.

Dry yellow leaves drifted by on the wind and fell under Shirley’s feet. She stepped on them as she walked, hearing the faint crackle of them breaking. It sounded like stepping on charred splinters of wood, like tiny tongues of flame murmuring and popping.

She lifted her head and looked around, but saw only an ordinary street. Old houses lined the road, standing in the drifting leaves, facing the unwelcome visitors with cold indifference.

Then Shirley suddenly noticed that something was wrong.

She did not know when it had started, but there was no one else on the street anymore.

The Sixth District really was quiet. In most places there were few pedestrians, and the few residents looked listless, cold, and withdrawn. But it had never been so empty that she could not see a single person!

An unpleasant feeling spread from the bottom of her heart. It vaguely reminded her of the dream she had been trapped in. She instinctively moved a little closer to Duncan—just as he suddenly stopped. With a thump, she crashed straight into his waist.

In the next second, Shirley drafted her full last words and even imagined three different designs for her gravestone. Then she quickly remembered that people crushed by the Subspace Shadows probably did not leave a body behind anyway…

Duncan's calm voice cut off the young lady's wild thoughts: "Looks like we're here."

"I'm so, so sorry, I really didn't mean to, please… huh?"

Shirley blurted out a string of pleas without thinking. Only then did she realize that the big boss in front of her did not seem angry at all. Right after that, she finally noticed that she had stopped before a building that looked as if it had been abandoned for who knew how many years.

It was a cathedral.

A community cathedral, the kind seen everywhere in the city-state of Pland, stood at the end of the lane.

It had the Deep Sea Cathedral's iconic slender spire, but dead vines and rotting grime hung everywhere on its black roof tiles and white stone walls. The main door, carved with complex sacred sigils, stood slightly open. The stained-glass windows beside it had fallen to pieces, leaving almost only warped iron frames. Through the crack of the door and the gaps in the broken windows, they could vaguely see a dark interior.

This had once been a sacred building, but now the air of ruin and neglect filled every crack between its bricks.

“…Is this the ‘cathedral’ that old man at the crossroads mentioned last time?” Shirley recalled their last trip here to investigate the Sixth District. “I remember he said a nun lived here, but that the nun was often not in the cathedral…”

“Falling into this state can’t be explained by ‘often not at home’,” Duncan said casually as he walked toward the cathedral’s main doors. “Rather than saying that nun often goes out, I’d say this place looks like it was forgotten eleven years ago.”

Shirley watched him walk toward the cathedral. She instinctively felt tense and repelled by that building, but after a moment’s hesitation she still followed in Duncan’s footsteps.

The next moment, Duncan pushed open the half-closed cathedral doors, and the scene inside the small cathedral appeared clearly before their eyes.

Warm, bright candlelight fell into Shirley’s eyes. Inside, the small cathedral was neat and spotless, lit from end to end. At the far end of the rows of benches, the statue of the Storm Goddess Gamona stood quietly amid the lights.

A nun who had been kneeling devoutly before the statue in prayer heard the door open, rose, and turned around.

She saw the visitors standing at the door and showed a gentle smile. “It has been a long time since anyone came to visit this cathedral.”

“Oh… looks like this really is the place.” Duncan looked at the smiling nun before him and said quietly, his expression calm: “The gap in the Veil.”

He blinked. In his eyes, the smiling nun kept the appearance of a living person for one instant, then in the next became a human-shaped heap of

writhing ash. Behind her, the cathedral itself fell into a bizarre state of superposition—flames roared over intact benches, while ash and sparks drifted down from the roof. The scene after a fire had burned everything to ruin and the scene of the intact cathedral overlapped at the same time, creating a strange and torn vision.

It was as if two completely different facts had been forced together inside this cathedral.

Chapter 149

On the outside, the community cathedral looked as if it had been abandoned for countless years, yet inside it was bright and spotless. At the same time, in Duncan's eyes the lit cathedral clearly carried another layer: a ruined scene, like another "fact" superimposed over it.

It gave Duncan a certain feeling. This little cathedral felt like an "error space" laid over the Mortal Realm, or a forgotten place trapped in a crack between time and space. Two completely different histories had once crossed here, yet the cathedral had remained at that crossing point, and time inside it had never moved forward again.

It had neither been destroyed nor survived that fire.

Then… what did the sister who stayed here alone know?

"It has been a long time since anyone came to visit this cathedral," the nun in a black priest's gown repeated softly. She smiled as she lifted her head, yet her gaze seemed to pass right through Shirley and Duncan standing before her. "Where are you from? Strange faces… you're not residents of this place, are you?"

Before them was a bright and cozy scene, yet under the nun's smiling, almost divine gaze, Shirley shrank her neck without knowing why. A chill crawled up her spine. She whispered nervously to Duncan: "I… why do I feel this place is so weird… Outside it looks so ruined, but inside…"

Duncan did not answer. He just patted Shirley's shoulder. From the girl's reaction, he had already guessed that she could only see one "face" of this

cathedral, most likely the side that had not been destroyed. But he did not yet know how to explain his guess to her—if they let Dog out now, then with the "eyes" of that Abyssal Hound, he probably could see the cathedral's real state.

But before he figured out what exactly this nun was, it was better not to let Shirley summon Dog out on impulse.

"We were passing by," Duncan said calmly to the nun, his face unchanged, as if he were just a citizen here to visit the cathedral. "Have you been here all this time?"

"Me? I have always lived in this cathedral," the nun replied with a small nod. "I have always been here in prayer, praying to the Great Presence."

"But the people in the neighborhood said the nun from this cathedral has not come back for a long time," Duncan went on, watching her reaction. "They said this cathedral has been neglected for a long period, that it looks almost abandoned."

The nun listened quietly to Duncan, showing no strong reaction at all, as if her heart had settled into an eternal calm.

She only gave a faint smile. "Oh? Is that so? But I have always been here… Perhaps they forgot the days of prayer and thought the cathedral was closed instead."

Duncan neither agreed nor denied it, but he had already confirmed that not only this cathedral had a problem. The entire Sixth District outside the cathedral had a problem.

This abandoned cathedral lay deep within the neighborhood. From the outside alone, it was clear it had been neglected for more than ten years. For ordinary people in this world, a cathedral was not only a place for spiritual comfort—it was also a facility that helped keep an area safe, guarding

against evil forces after nightfall. It was where many commoners went for help when they suffered mental troubles or were tormented by nightmares. Yet such an important facility had been abandoned for eleven whole years, and the residents of the Sixth District felt nothing was wrong with that. They only mentioned lightly that “the nun hasn’t been around recently”?

Imagine a neighborhood that had its water and power cut off for eleven years straight, and the locals felt nothing was strange about it. If outsiders asked, they only said lightly, “The water and power people haven’t been on duty lately.” How bizarre would that be!

As for the nun in this cathedral… Duncan still was not sure what that mass of ashen humanoid shapes, which kept revealing its true form in his sight, really was. But from their brief conversation, he could feel that she… did not seem hostile.

Not only that, but her mind seemed to be in a strange state. He could not say she lacked reason entirely, but she certainly was not truly clear-headed.

Duncan probed with a few indirect questions, and the nun in the cathedral answered them all calmly. Yet that very calmness in her answers… was a sign of her unsound mind.

Under normal circumstances, if a stranger suddenly walked into a cathedral and started bombarding the duty nun with a string of unrelated questions, the nun should at least feel something was odd.

She still had reason—but not much of it left.

“Do you wish to offer a prayer? Or do you need help with calming your mind and driving away evil influences?”

The nun asked with a gentle smile and a soft voice.

“Thank you, but that won’t be necessary,” Duncan said, shaking his head. He let his gaze sweep casually around them, then asked as if offhand, “By

the way, what about this cathedral's guardians?"

Every cathedral was supposed to have guardians stationed in it. Even the smallest community cathedral in the Slum Quarter kept a guard force enough to handle ordinary threats. This cathedral should have been no exception.

"The guardians… the guardians are resting in the cathedral. They only appear after nightfall," the nun said, her smile unchanged. "Do you need something from the guardians?"

Duncan did not answer. His eyes slowly moved over the benches beside the nun.

In his vision, the phantom of a great fire that had burned everything, of collapsed heaps of ash and rubble, lay over the brightly lit cathedral like overlapping frames of film. In that other superimposed layer, there were more than a few… charred bodies.

"Are the guardians resting over there?" Duncan raised his hand and pointed into the distance. In Shirley's eyes, there were only two empty rows of benches in that direction.

The nun paused for a moment, then followed Duncan's pointing finger with her gaze. After a brief silence, she said softly, "Shh… they are sleeping."

Duncan made a small sound of acknowledgment and then asked casually, "May we look around?"

"Of course. The cathedral is open to visitors," the nun said with a light nod. "Please feel free to walk around. I will continue my prayers—if you need help, you may call me at any time."

After saying this, the strange nun really did turn and walk back toward the Goddess's statue, leaving Duncan and Shirley completely to themselves.

It was only after the nun left that Shirley, who had been tense for so long, finally let out a deep breath. At this point she did not even have the energy to be afraid of Duncan, because the eerie atmosphere filling every corner of the cathedral had already made Dog, still in his hidden state, restless. That strange tension was flowing straight into her mind through the mental link, making her instinctively edge closer to Duncan. “W-what is going on in this place… Why does that nun feel so creepy? She looks normal, but somehow everything about her feels wrong…”

“There seem to be two cathedrals here,” Duncan said softly, giving a simple, blunt explanation. “One has already burned down, and the other is still intact. They are superimposed on this place in time and space. As for the nun in the cathedral… she is neither dead nor alive.”

Shirley froze. It took her a full half minute before she managed to speak again in confusion and shock: “What do you mean?”

Duncan gave her a look. “You really should read more books later—if that doesn’t work, I can teach you.”

Then, without waiting for Shirley’s reply, he walked straight toward the back of the cathedral.

The nun had said the cathedral was open to visitors, so of course he was going to “take a look around” as he pleased.

Shirley stood dazed for a moment, then hurried to follow him. They walked past the neatly arranged benches and passed by the statue and prayer altar at their far end.

The serene nun was already kneeling before the statue of the Storm Goddess, both hands lightly pressed to her chest as she devoutly offered benediction. It was as if she had completely forgotten the visitors, as if she

had been kneeling here for the past eleven years, maintaining an unbroken prayer.

Duncan blinked, and the nun turned again into a writhing mass of ashen humanoids piled beside a charred, broken prayer altar. Tiny sparks of fire fell from the dome above like drifting leaves.

Suddenly sensing something, he lifted his head to look up at the statue of the Storm Goddess.

The statue in its long dress stood quietly on the high platform, but a jagged crack ran straight across its head!

In that brief instant, Duncan saw the core of the truth hidden in the double-layered cathedral. He clearly saw a dim fissure opening where the Goddess's stone head should have been. Inside that crack, faint, chaotic light and shadow stirred, like a terrible eye lying sideways. In the depths of its pupil were scenes that absolutely did not belong to the Mortal Realm. The "holy" aura that should have surrounded the Goddess's statue had vanished without a trace. On this eerie, frightening stone figure, only cold and emptiness coiled.

In the next instant, that horrific sight vanished as if it had never been. Gamona's statue still stood quietly on the high platform, gazing down on everything with solemn majesty, radiating a presence that brought both comfort and awe.

The nun kneeling before the Goddess's statue suddenly opened her eyes. She tilted her head slightly and looked calmly at Duncan.

"Do you wish to offer a prayer to the Goddess?"

Chapter 150: The Secret in the underground sanctum

“Do you wish to offer a prayer to the Goddess?”

To be honest, in that instant, Duncan’s first instinct was that there was something wrong with Storm Goddess Gamona—that this deity, who was supposed to shelter humans, had a cruel hidden side. Because of that, terrible shadows lurked deep in the city-state, and the twisted look that had flashed across the statue was the proof.

But the next second, another doubt rose in his mind: if Storm Goddess Gamona really had a problem, then why were all the other cathedrals in the city perfectly normal?

He had seen other cathedrals of the Church of the Deep Sea before. There was a community cathedral near the antique shop, and back then there had been another beside the Ocean City Museum. Even though he had not gone in to investigate them carefully, he had lingered nearby, and the aura those cathedrals gave off was clearly different from that of the strange cathedral before him.

He had also dealt with other clergy, from the lowest priests and guardians to people like Vanna, an Inquisitor standing at the very top of the city-state. All those who served Storm Goddess Gamona day and night were normal. They were even more strong-willed and clear-headed than most people.

He ignored the nun and lifted his head to look at the statue.

After that brief, startling glimpse, the strange crack in the statue's head did not appear again. Even in the overlaid image of the cathedral, the statue only looked blackened by smoke, as if the crack had sensed something and taken the initiative to hide.

Duncan frowned.

The weirdness of this cathedral was clearly an exception. So if the problem was not with Storm Goddess Gamona… then what he had just seen might be some other power using this cathedral as a Node, trying to corrupt the Mortal Realm.

But what exactly was that thing?

The shape of that crack did not seem related to the Sun God at all, and it did not make him think of any fragments of the Sun. If anything… the murky light and shadow surging within the crack reminded him of the chaos outside the hull of the Vanished.

"Do you wish to offer a prayer to the Goddess?"

The nun's voice came again. She sounded neither impatient nor urging. It was as if some key word had been triggered, so that as long as Duncan and Shirley stood near the statue, she kept repeating the same question over and over.

Shirley looked a little at a loss. She instinctively turned to Duncan. Duncan finally responded. He calmly fixed his gaze on the nun and asked: "Are you offering this prayer to your Goddess?"

It should have been a question with an obvious answer. Any normal believer would have given a clear yes at this moment. But the nun's reaction made Shirley's eyes widen.

"I… don't know," the nun said, shaking her head with a calm face, as if she did not feel there was anything wrong with her answer. "I am only praying.

She told me to pray here.”

“Who is She?” Duncan frowned at once.

“The Great Presence.” The nun smiled.

Yet in the nun’s gentle smile, Shirley felt a chill rise in her heart.

“I do not pray to any deity,” Duncan said quietly. He unobtrusively pulled Shirley back half a step, out of the area of the prayer platform. “Including the Goddess you speak of.”

“Oh, what a pity.” The nun let out a soft sigh, bowed her head again, and no longer paid any attention to Duncan and Shirley.

Duncan stared at the writhing cluster of ashen humanoids for a few seconds. After he confirmed that the ash really was no longer paying him any mind, he turned away and walked toward another part of the cathedral.

This small cathedral was limited in size, with almost no place to hide anything. Apart from the main hall that housed the statue, there were only a few rooms connected to the hall and a single basement.

Duncan first led Shirley to check the nearby rooms. They found nothing worth noting. In the end, they found the stairs leading down to the basement at the end of a corridor on the outer side of the main hall.

“Are we really going down there?” Looking at the pitch-black stairs before her, Shirley was clearly uneasy. She could not help glancing back toward the main hall. “That weird nun won’t suddenly come after us, will she?”

“That ‘nun’ is obviously trapped in the main hall and cannot stray far from the statue,” Duncan shook his head and said. “But if she really does come to attack… then we will have to fight. In that state… it’s hard to say she is still a living human.”

Shirley swallowed. Normally, she was quite bold. But no matter how bold, this was her first time sneaking into a cathedral of the Church of the Deep Sea to stir up trouble. Years of ingrained tension and awe made her heart pound wildly.

But she knew she had better not refuse. Compared to a nun who had mutated from a mortal and a shadow from Subspace, she had a rough idea of which was more dangerous.

Just then, Duncan spoke again, making Shirley, who had finally steeled herself, jump all over again: “Right, summon Dog.”

Shirley’s eyes went wide at once. “Huh?! Summon Dog? Inside the Storm Goddess’s cathedral?!”

“This place is probably no longer the Storm Goddess’s cathedral,” Duncan shook his head and said. “It’s hard to say what exactly holds the upper hand here now. Go ahead and summon Dog. Look, even I am standing in this ‘cathedral’. Could a Abyssal demon be more out of place than me?”

Shirley thought about it and felt that this actually made some sense. Of course, even if it had not made sense, she would not have dared to disagree. So she honestly raised her arm and summoned Dog into the Mortal Realm.

Black flames and swirling smoke rose up. In the blink of an eye, the huge Abyssal Hound appeared in front of Duncan.

As soon as the summoning ended, Dog, very well-practiced in his job, dropped down at Duncan’s feet. His skeletal tail wagged like a five-speed electric fan. “I salute you, great Dun—”

“Enough, you don’t have to do this every time,” Duncan cut him off with a wave before he could finish. Having one noisy Goathead already gave him enough of a headache. He really did not want another dog with the same style hanging around him. “You should already sense that something is

wrong with this cathedral. Now see it with your own eyes. I may need your ‘eye for detail’ later.”

Dog nimbly scrambled up from the floor and turned his head to look around the corridor and the stairs leading down to the basement at its end. A faint light flickered in his hollow scarlet eye sockets.

“This place really is cursed…” the Abyssal Hound’s voice was hoarse and low. “Just looking at it makes my eyes swim…”

He paused, as if making a deeper judgment, then turned slightly to Duncan and said: “It’s a little like that abandoned factory from before, but more twisted than that. This distortion has probably already pushed the Mortal Realm to the limit of what it can bear… Yes, it looks like we really have found one of the key points on this layer of the Veil.”

“The distortion has already pushed the Mortal Realm to its limit… no wonder I can observe it directly,” Duncan nodded in understanding. His gaze fell on the stairs ahead. “We have already checked the whole cathedral. What is left now… should be only this basement. In most cathedrals of the Church of the Deep Sea, the area ahead is called the ‘underground sanctum’.”

“I’m starting to get excited,” Dog said, shaking his ugly head so that the chain around his neck clattered. “This is the first time in my life I’ve marched openly into a forbidden area of a cathedral of the Church of the Deep Sea… I’ve never seen what it looks like down there!”

Shirley gave Dog a strange look at once. “Can you not sound like some creep about to sneak into the ladies’ restroom?”

Dog: “…”

Duncan ignored this pair of dog-bred brats. He had already stepped past Dog and gone down the stairs, arriving at the door that led into the

underground sanctum.

For such a small community cathedral, this so-called “underground sanctum” was only a spacious basement. The door leading into the underground sanctum was an oak door reinforced with a steel frame and Sacred Sigils, and marked with a divine blessing.

Duncan set his hand on the door and pushed gently. He found that the door was not locked, but when he pushed harder he felt some resistance, as if something on the other side was bracing against it to keep it from opening.

“There is something on the other side of the door.” Duncan stepped back a little and studied the black oak door before him.

For some reason, once he reached the doorway of the underground sanctum, that strange “overlapping” scene faded. All he saw before his eyes now was this single door.

It was as if the two “branches” that had been overlaid within the cathedral had converged here, leaving only a single Mortal Realm.

“Should we just smash the door open?” Shirley came up behind him. She had already lifted the chain in her hand, eagerness written on her face. Dog also made ready—by wrapping his paws around his head and curling himself up into a meteor hammer.

“…That might destroy clues,” Duncan stopped the dog-swinging maiden from using her traditional technique. He laid one hand on the rune-covered door. A tiny flame rose between his fingers and quickly traced along the grooves and lines on the door. “In theory, this door should count as an supernatural item, so…”

In the next second, the cathedral door that had once been given a divine blessing turned into tinder for the fire of spirit form. Ghostly green flame

flared up along its surface. The door faithfully carried out its Master’s command.

It burned itself away.

As the door turned to ash and scattered, the thing that had been braced against it appeared before Duncan and the others and fell to the floor with a thud.

It was a nun in a black robe and skirt—covered in wounds, a longsword still clutched in her hand. Even in death, she still glared at something in the darkness.

When Shirley saw the woman’s face clearly, a chill rose from the depths of her heart.

“Is that… the nun we just saw?”

Chapter 151: The Fear of Abyssal Demons

Duncan bent down to examine her.

It really was that nun—the same nun who had just been speaking with Duncan and Shirley, and who, in theory, was still in the main hall praying.

But now she lay here, dead near the entrance to the underground sanctum. Until the moment Duncan pushed the door, she had been using her own body to brace it shut.

It seemed she had been trying to keep something from entering the underground sanctum. Yet judging from her last state before she fell, it also looked as if she had fought desperately against something inside the underground sanctum, then shut the door before she died to keep that thing from escaping.

“She looks… like she just died…”

At this point, Shirley also mustered her courage and stepped closer. She leaned from behind Duncan to peer at the body. Only after two or three seconds did she speak carefully.

“Yes, it looks as if she died not long ago. She even…” Duncan spoke as he placed his hand on the nun’s arm. “She even still has warmth.”

The corpse at the entrance of the underground sanctum still held residual heat. The blood on her wounded body had not yet dried. This even gave Duncan the illusion that when he and Shirley first stepped into the

cathedral, the battle in this basement had still been going on, that this nun had still been alive. Maybe… even when they began to search through the cathedral, this nun had still been breathing.

But that was impossible.

This cathedral had been abandoned for eleven years. The supernatural manifestation that had taken place in the city-state of Pland had also happened eleven years ago. If this cathedral really was a key Node on the Veil, then everything here should have happened and ended eleven years back. The nun who had fought to her last breath in the underground sanctum… could not have died only just now.

Duncan's expression grew serious. He slowly straightened up and looked past the doorway.

As he had expected, the underground sanctum of this community cathedral was only a slightly more spacious basement. There was no light in the hall. Even the ever-burning oil lamps and gas lamps meant to repel evil had long since gone out. Only the faint glow pouring in through the doorway lit the scene within. In the dimness, he could just see a statue of the Goddess standing quietly at the center of the room. On both sides, columns hung with scripture banners stood in rows, and niches for storing holy relics were set into the walls.

Duncan stepped over the nun's corpse and searched the basement for signs of battle. He saw gouges on the walls and pillars where blades had struck, pockmarks left by bullets, and scorched marks left by fire. These had all been left by the fight.

But the one thing he did not find was an "enemy". He did not find any of the "intruders" that nun had fought so desperately against before she died.

He turned his head to look at Dog, who was following behind Shirley with his head lowered, cautiously observing everything around them. “Dog, can you see anything?”

“I see signs that time and space have been badly twisted… On the surface, there doesn’t seem to be that kind of ‘overlapping Mortal Realm’ we saw in the cathedral above, but in fact the distortion of time and space here is worse than anywhere else,” Dog said, his tone unusually grave. As the only occult specialist in this three-‘person’ team, his analysis was far more systematic than Duncan’s wild guesses. “In my sight, the whole underground sanctum is shrouded in a thin mist. The wrong time and space have completely replaced the Mortal Realm. But… apart from this distortion of time and space, I haven’t found anything else.”

“What about the ‘intruders’ who attacked this place?” Duncan frowned. “That nun can’t have been playing a mind game with the air, can she?”

“…There are no intruders,” Dog said, sniffing—though he did not actually have a respiratory system. “No scent of living beings. No scent of Abyssal demons or creatures from the Spirit Realm.”

He paused again, then added: “Please trust my judgment on this. A Abyssal Hound’s greatest talent is hunting. Telling prey apart by their scent in any environment is a basic skill for a predator, unless…”

Duncan raised an eyebrow. “Unless?”

Dog quickly swept his gaze around, suddenly much more cautious. He lowered his voice as he came up beside Duncan. “Unless something from Subspace came out… I can’t track that. But if it really is something from Subspace, you should be more familiar with it than I am…”

As soon as Duncan heard that, his face went blank. “Sorry. I’m not familiar at all.”

Dog hastily lowered his head. “If you say you’re not familiar, then you’re not familiar…”

Duncan thought for a moment. He knew Dog definitely did not believe him, but he really was not familiar with Subspace. On the other hand, Dog’s words had indeed reminded him of something.

He recalled the crack he had glimpsed in that instant when he looked at the statue of the Goddess in the cathedral’s main hall. He remembered the chaotic light and shadow leaking from that crack. He remembered the strange manifestations he had seen beneath the hull of the Vanished.

Subspace… was it really something from Subspace that had escaped?

“If it really did come from Subspace…” Duncan frowned, half speaking to himself. “How did it end up barging straight into the Storm Goddess’s sanctuary? Isn’t this supposed to be the safest, best-defended place? And judging from the traces at the scene, it doesn’t look like the intruders attacked from outside. It looks more like they appeared directly inside the sanctuary and then tried to break out…”

“That, I don’t know,” Dog said, shaking his head. “The secrets of the Four Great Churches are a blind spot in the knowledge of Abyssal demons. And Subspace is an officially recognized taboo. Even Dreadfiends do not pry into its mysteries. In fact, from my point of view, humans are even crazier than demons in this field. They actually dare to study Subspace, and after all these years nothing has gone wrong…”

“Humans have always been a bold species,” Duncan said offhand. Then he looked at Dog. “But I am a bit surprised. The Abyssal Deep of the Deep Sea lies right next to Subspace, yet you Abyssal demons are even more afraid of that place than humans? Isn’t Subspace basically your front yard?”

“People who live beside a volcano don’t do it because they love drinking lava,” Dog said, hanging his head as he explained to the big boss. “We live right next to Subspace, so we know better than humans how terrifying it is to fall in.”

Duncan looked thoughtful and finally asked the question he had failed to ask last time. “…So that’s why you fear the Vanished returning from Subspace just as much as humans do?”

Dog shrank his neck and gave Duncan a very careful look, as if he were afraid that talking about this topic might accidentally offend the Master of the Vanished standing before him. But since the big boss had brought it up, he did not dare refuse to answer. He could only say honestly: “Actually… if the Vanished had only returned from Subspace, it would not have been that scary. The key point is that, during the earliest period, that ship kept ‘falling’ back out of the Mortal Realm from time to time. It was like it was bouncing between two dimensions, going back and forth nonstop between Subspace and the Mortal Realm…”

Duncan had only asked casually, but he had not expected to hear information like this. His heart stirred at once. “Bouncing between the Mortal Realm and Subspace?”

“Yes. Each time it passed, it went straight through the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep, sweeping up everything it encountered along the way, like a cannonball charging blindly forward,” Dog said, and his voice clearly trembled at the memory. “I still remember a terrifying scene. The ship fell from the upper layers like an ever-burning meteor of fire. Flames wrapped around screaming humans and a twisted hull. Those mindless, brawling Abyssal demons scattered in panic, but in an instant an immense force swept them into the flames. They fused with those humans into grotesque, twisted lumps, which were then torn apart and scattered into the depths of the Abyssal Deep…

“The Vanished punched through the layers like that, crashed into the depths of Subspace, then two days later crawled back out from below, and then… did it all over again.”

As he spoke, Dog gulped with difficulty. A rough rasping came from his throat, along with the sound of corrosive fluids seething.

“Back then, even some of the most mindless, dull Abyssal demons stopped fighting for a short time. Every day they just stared blankly in the direction of the Spirit Realm. Fear even outweighed their urge to attack, becoming their new instinct… and I was one of those marked most deeply by that fear.”

Duncan listened with a blank face. After a long moment, he finally said: “Then… I understand why you have such deep psychological shadows.”

Dog mustered his courage and looked up at Duncan. “You… you really didn’t know any of this yourself?”

Duncan almost lost his composure. He didn’t know a damn thing! He hadn’t done any of that! Why did every old mess have to be dumped on his head?

But no matter how much he complained, he could only grumble about it in his heart. In front of Dog, he could only keep a straight face. “…Maybe I just didn’t notice.”

Dog: “…”

Seeing how crushed the Abyssal Hound looked, Duncan sighed and added: “I’ll pay attention from now on.”

His tone was very sincere.

Dog was so moved he did not even dare move.

After that, Duncan fell into brief thought.

If everything Dog said was true, then the Vanished… had once gone through a period of complete runaway state? It had not simply sailed back from Subspace. For quite a long time, it had been “bouncing” back and forth between the Mortal Realm and Subspace?!

Chapter 152: When in Doubt…

Duncan had not expected that a casual question would make Dog spill such important information about the Vanished. He had already heard this Abyssal Hound talk about the Vanished's fearsome name in the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea, but who would have thought that this fame had been "smashed out" in such a blunt and brutal way?!

A ghost ship that kept shaking between Subspace and the Mortal Realm was like a cannon shell flying back and forth between a rooftop and the foundations. Each time it rocked, it smashed through the "floors" of the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea. Nothing survived wherever it passed. Every solid thing that touched it was dragged into Subspace. And from the sound of it, this had gone on for quite some time.

No wonder Abyssal demons like Dog had carved fear of the Vanished into their bones. A calamity that showed up every few days to slaughter people in front of you suddenly stopped, and then the captain came down from the ship, smiling and greeting you. Who would not have their knees buckling? Even if Dog did not even have tendons in his legs, they would still cramp.

After all, just because the ship had stopped in the Mortal Realm now did not mean it would stay. What if… a certain ghost captain suddenly wanted to go back to Subspace to visit some relatives?

But compared with the huge mess the Vanished had made back then, Duncan cared more about the state of that ship itself at the time, and what kind of state the real Captain Duncan had been in.

Was that kind of “shaking” something the real Captain Duncan had done on purpose? Or had it been some kind of out-of-control lost voyage? Had Goathead known what was happening back then? If all of this had been done on purpose, what had “Captain Duncan” and Goathead been trying to do? And if it had all come from the runaway state…

…then things would get even crazier.

Would the Vanished… go into a runaway state again?!

All this time, the Vanished had been Duncan’s greatest support, and also where his true body was. The safety of that ship was the same as his own safety. He explored that ship and took control of it so he could make that safety more sure. But if the whole ship had the hidden danger of a runaway state and might suddenly “smash” back into Subspace from the Mortal Realm again… then was the control he had over the Vanished right now still of any use?

Could he pull back a ghost ship that was charging madly toward Subspace?

The Vanished’s current steady sailing on the Boundless Sea might only be a short-lived balance. Its real normal state might actually be “runaway state”. That possibility spread through his heart beyond his control and made Duncan grow restless.

What troubled him even more was the big door at the bottom of the Vanished’s hull that led into Subspace, and Goathead’s tense reaction after learning that the door had opened a crack. That seemed to faintly prove his worries—

The Vanished was not stable, and Subspace’s call to that ship had never stopped, not even for a moment.

Duncan took a slow breath without showing anything on his face and forced himself to calm down.

No matter how much he thought about it, he still did not have enough power to meddle in things related to Subspace. He still knew too little about the occult.

If he wanted to gather more knowledge about Subspace, dealing with more supernatural events was one way. And right now, this cathedral in front of him… this cathedral that might once have been invaded by Subspace.

“We should pay more attention to this place,” Duncan said as he shook his head. “If something from Subspace did invade the underground sanctum, then what happened eleven years ago is much more complicated than anyone imagined…”

He raised his head and looked at the big door that had once been sealed.

“The nun here held this door before she died,” Duncan said. “Maybe to keep what was in the sanctum from getting out. But can a single door really block intruders from Subspace?”

“Invasion from Subspace also depends on the situation,” Dog said, thinking it over. “In most cases, the Mortal Realm is protected by the Gods… fine, I don’t really like Them, but the Mortal Realm really is under the Gods’ effective shelter. Subspace has a hard time affecting this side directly. What can come over here is usually not the true body. At most it’s some projection, some corruption, or even just illusions thrown out by using people’s minds as a lens…”

Dog stopped mid-sentence and stared at Duncan, suddenly nervous.

In his eyes, the light-and-shadow vortex inside this human body was spinning in chaos. Mad gleams kept rising from it, enough to send even demons’ minds into a runaway state.

This ghost captain who had come back from Subspace… damn it, he himself was the biggest Subspace invasion in this place!

“Keep talking. Then what? What about Subspace invasion?” Duncan asked.

In Dog’s eyes, the very embodiment of a Subspace invasion lowered his head and curiously asked about Subspace invasions.

“I… I mean, under normal conditions, a Subspace invasion can be blocked by the holy facilities in a cathedral,” Dog said. “And since what comes in isn’t the true body, as long as you cut off the invasion channel, the part that stays in the Mortal Realm will soon fade away…” Dog swallowed hard as he explained Subspace invasion to the walking Subspace invasion. “Of course, what a terrible price you have to pay in the process is another story…”

“So that’s how it works,” Duncan said with a knowing nod. When he looked again at the nun lying on the ground, his eyes were filled with even more respect than before. “She must have used everything she had to try to stop that disaster.”

“But she didn’t really succeed, right?” Shirley’s voice suddenly came from the side. Because what Duncan and Dog were talking about was either too advanced or too scary, she had not found any chance to speak until now. “The big fire eleven years ago still happened…”

“The fire eleven years ago was caused by the fragment of the Sun, but in this cathedral we have found traces that seem to come from Subspace. We still can’t say how these two things are linked,” Duncan said, shaking his head. Then it was as if something had just come to him. With a thoughtful look, he slowly walked to the statue of the Goddess standing in the middle of the underground sanctum. “But… I suddenly feel curious about one thing.”

He raised his head and looked up at the statue of the Goddess, which was a little different from the statue of Gamona in the cathedral on the surface. This statue stood in the dim light, with no sign of damage on its surface.

“What are you curious about?” Shirley came over, gave the statue a careful glance, and asked in a small voice.

“This Storm Goddess—what was She doing?” Duncan raised his hand and pointed at the statue. “The cathedral was invaded, the priest died in battle, and only a ghostly shadow that keeps praying was left outside like a leftover soul. Why did the God here have no reaction at all? At the very least… She should have given some warning to the believers in the other cathedrals and asked them to come support this place, right?”

“I don’t really know much about the Gods either, but this does sound suspicious,” Dog muttered. “Even though the Gods aren’t closely tied to the mortal world, they really do care about their own ‘holy places’. These buildings that gather congregations are like ‘anchors’ for the Gods in the mortal world. Now one of those anchors got pulled out in silence, and after eleven years… there has been no reaction at all. That’s not right.”

Duncan thought for a moment, then suddenly raised his right hand. A tiny flame appeared out of thin air on his fingertip, its ghostly green light shining around the statue.

With a clatter of chains, Dog instantly backed away two steps: “W-What are you going to do?”

“When in doubt, light a little fire,” Duncan said with a smile. “Maybe we can burn something that is hiding into showing itself.”

Dog jumped in fright and almost reminded Duncan that this was the underground sanctum, and they might bring Gamona’s gaze down on them. But before he could say it, he held it back. This place had already been messed up to this degree. Who knew how much holiness it still had? And the big boss in front of him was about to do his proper job as a “Subspace invasion”. Why was he even talking?

Even so, he calmly edged a few more steps away and tugged Shirley to stand farther back as well.

If some kind of divine punishment really struck in a moment, the big boss might not be afraid, but he and Shirley would not be able to take it.

Duncan noticed Dog's movements, but he did not care.

Of course, he did not want to draw the Storm Goddess's gaze onto himself. But in the main hall of the cathedral just now, he had already confirmed that this "holy place" had been completely corrupted. Even the statue was wrapped with the power of Subspace. Thinking about how the abnormal state here had been hidden for eleven years without anyone finding it, it was clear that the deity's link to this place had already been cut.

Now, this place that had once been holy had long lost its holiness. Only shadows remained.

The spirit form flame burned in silence and dropped to the floor like drops of water. The hazy, unreal fire quickly rippled through the underground sanctum and filled the whole room in the blink of an eye.

Then the flames that had spread to every corner slowly went out without a sound.

Shirley and Dog looked at each other. After a long moment, Shirley finally spoke in a careful voice: "Did you… find anything?"

Duncan looked in mild surprise at the little flame still jumping on his finger, then at the empty underground sanctum where nothing at all had happened.

Was there really nothing here? Or… was the Power of Flame not enough to pry up the Veil that covered this place?

He frowned. And just then, a very faint whisper, almost like a hallucination, suddenly entered his ears—

“Who is there?”

Duncan started and snapped his head up, looking toward where the voice had come from.

Gamona’s statue stood quietly in the dark.

Chapter 153: Space-Time Lock

In the dark, the statue of the Storm Goddess Gamona still stood quietly in the center of the underground sanctum, veiled and looking down at the mortal world.

Of course, by strict doctrine, the “Goddess” in the underground sanctum was another side of Gamona and should be called the “Maiden of the Still Sea”.

Duncan stared hard at the cold stone statue. He was sure he had just heard a voice, a whisper like something from a dream, coming from that statue.

Yet Shirley and Dog, who were standing right next to him, still showed no reaction. Clearly, Duncan was the only one who had heard that voice.

“Mr. Duncan?” Shirley had also noticed Duncan’s strange behavior by now. She widened her eyes a little in nervousness and leaned against Dog without meaning to. “Did you find something?”

“Did either of you hear any sound just now?” Duncan pinched out the flame on his fingertip. As he spoke in a low voice, he moved closer to carefully study the statue of the Maiden of the Still Sea.

“Sound?” Shirley and Dog looked at each other and shook their heads. “No.”

The statue of the Goddess did not react at all to Duncan’s closer approach. No other sound came.

Duncan felt that he might have been a bit reckless this time.

He had thought the link between the Storm Goddess and this cathedral had already been cut. When he summoned Dog and burned down the chapel door earlier, no manifestations had appeared. So he had slowly loosened up while exploring. He had not expected that one burst of fire would draw the deity's gaze—if that faint question just now really had come from Gamona.

So he did a small bit of self-reflection in his heart and decided that the next time he was reckless, he should be a little more careful.

At the same time, as he was reflecting, a new doubt suddenly rose in his mind:

Judging from the state of this cathedral, before he and Shirley came in it had clearly been completely abandoned and forgotten. The link between the Storm Goddess Gamona and this place had also clearly been blocked. In theory, his flame should be another "invading force" inside this cathedral. Burning with his fire should only have made the corruption and blocking of this cathedral even worse, like lighting another fire on ruins that had already been badly burned. So how…

…had the link between the Storm Goddess and this place instead grown stronger for a moment after he lit his fire?

Wasn't he the intruder here? Shouldn't his flames be very destructive to the power of a deity that held the attribute of order? How had he ended up "burning the Goddess awake"?

The more Duncan thought about it, the more confused he felt, but he did not let his thoughts run wild for long.

In the end, he still could not be sure whether that faint whisper had really been Gamona's voice. He was just guessing based on that idea. The real problem in front of him now was thinking about what to do next with this strange cathedral.

After that whisper died away, nothing else happened. Duncan did not know what a Goddess usually did with Her time, but right now She did not seem to plan on keeping Her gaze on this place. The rest of the underground sanctum still stayed as it had been at first. The fire he had released had not lifted the Veil the way it had in the abandoned factory.

He still could not sense anything on the far side of the Veil. The flames he had left in that split body of the umbrella fiend were still missing without a trace. He could only be sure that the fire was still burning and had even started to spread, but he could not touch the “dimension” where those flames were.

This cathedral was indeed an important node on the Veil, but with only his and Shirley’s strength, it seemed hard to pry this place open.

With the condition of his current body, and with the distance between the Vanished and the city-state of Pland, it was also hard for him to call up a larger scale of flames. It would be hard to make a bigger stir here.

As these thoughts flashed through his mind, a faint idea took shape in Duncan’s heart.

It was time for him to once again play the part of “enthusiastic citizen Mr. Duncan”.

This cathedral had been hidden until today. Some nameless force had been blocking outsiders from peeking into it. So what if… he forcibly took the lid off?

He was very curious how the Deep Sea Church of the city-state of Pland would react, and even more curious about what the Storm Goddess would do. Since he could not open the Veil here by himself, he might as well turn this place into a big news event.

Of course, this time it would not work to just find a few patrolling Night Watchers and report it to them. That might only get the first group of investigators who came killed. He had to think carefully about how to turn this place into big news in a way that was both safe and effective.

As he thought, a small smile appeared on Duncan's face without him noticing. It was the smile of a mischief-maker planning a big piece of trouble. But this smile scared Shirley and Dog beside him. Dog, especially, clamped his tail down on the spot: "M-M-Mr. Duncan, do you have a plan?"

Duncan waved his hand as soon as he heard the question. "Nothing much. I just plan to do my part to uphold the city's order."

Dog let out a gurgling sound in his throat. He thought that even if you said those words to the mad demons of the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea, no one would believe them. The look on the big boss's face just now had clearly been the smile of a Subspace intruder who had finally figured out what a Subspace invasion really was and was getting ready to carry one out…

"All right, there's nothing more to see here," Duncan said. He did not care about Shirley and Dog's reactions. He only glanced back at Gamona's statue and gave it a meaningful look, then turned and walked toward the exit door. "We shouldn't stay here for long."

The group hurried toward the exit, but before they left, Shirley could not help stopping again. "Mr. Duncan, wh-what about this dead nun?"

Duncan also stopped. He quietly looked at the young woman who had died after fighting with all her strength.

She was still very young, so young that it made one feel regret. She had not been a Guardian whose job was fighting for the Church, yet she had died

here in the dark of the underground sanctum with a sword in her hand.

Duncan suddenly realized a problem.

A nun… Why had a nun been guarding the sanctum? Under normal conditions, shouldn't there have been a whole squad of specially trained Guardians stationed here?

He thought back to the scene he had seen in the main hall earlier.

That squad of Guardians seemed to have died in the main hall of the cathedral. And from the scene he had seen in that "overlaid Mortal Realm", those Guardians had not died in battle. It was more like they had all suddenly dropped dead while they were sitting on the benches in prayer.

The Guardians who should have been stationed in the underground sanctum had suddenly died in the cathedral's main hall, with no sign of battle on their bodies. The nun who should have stayed in the main hall had instead died alone in the sanctum in battle. The intruders seemed to be from Subspace, yet they had left no trace after the fight. After that, the cathedral had been sealed and forgotten, while some sort of "echo" of the nun had returned to the main hall to go on with the daily prayers…

Duncan's attention came back to the Mortal Realm. He quietly looked at the nun for a few seconds and said softly: "I'm sorry. I can't bury you. You will have to stay here for now. Maybe someone will come and find out the truth of what happened back then."

For this matter, he really did need to borrow the hands of some "professionals".

Duncan stood up and walked toward the exit that led to the main hall. Behind him, Shirley could not help speaking up: "Ah, we're just leaving her here?"

“This is called preserving the scene,” Duncan said without looking back. “Come on. The investigation here is not over yet. It’s just that from now on, we won’t need to do the work ourselves.”

Shirley let out an “oh” as if she half understood, then pulled Dog along and followed Duncan’s steps. They left the underground sanctum and walked toward the stairs ahead that led up to the main hall.

A faint knocking sound came from behind them.

Duncan stopped short and turned his head toward the source of the sound.

A dark wooden door stood at the entrance to the main hall. The door was slightly ajar. Iron bands and rivets had been used to strengthen it, and faint traces of holy runes could be seen on the panels.

Shirley glanced back, and her eyes slowly grew wide in horror.

Then she turned her head again and saw Duncan’s face set in a deep, dark expression.

“T-The door…” Shirley raised her hand and pointed toward it. Her mouth opened and closed a few times, but no words came out.

“I see it,” Duncan cut her off. He walked back to the sanctum’s entrance, looked at the dark door, and reached out to push it lightly.

The door was not locked, but when he tried to push it further, he felt resistance.

Someone on the other side was holding the door.

He drew back his hand and thought in silence for a few seconds, holding back the urge to light another fire and burn the door open.

He already knew what things would look like after opening the door. The strange phenomena here made him give up the idea of using crude methods

to keep trying again and again.

“Twisted space and time… it really is twisted to quite a degree,” Duncan said.

At the same time, in the great Deep Sea cathedral in the upper city, the calm-faced Vanna finished her daily prayers. After assigning today’s work to her subordinates, she sent all her attendants away and went alone into the depths of the grand, holy building.

This was the archive of the great cathedral. Under the Goddess’s gaze, this archive held all the records of supernatural matters that were not fit for the public eye.

In a sense, this place stored the history of the city-state of Pland. It stored the Church’s “memory” of this land.

Chapter 154:

The archive was managed by an old priest. He was already quite old, with a hunched back and thin, messy white hair. On his head he wore a complex lens array made of brass cranks and crystal lenses, and his clothes still smelled faintly of machine oil.

The old priest sat behind a dark, ring-shaped desk. Using the lenses, he studied a mechanical device that looked like a Rubik’s cube. With the help of several delicate tools, he had taken the cube apart into a pile of tiny parts. The light of a gas lamp shone on the pieces, making them glimmer.

When Vanna walked over, her tall figure blocked the light at the side. Only then did the old priest raise his head. He pushed the lenses away from his eyes with a finger. When he saw who it was, he smiled and said: “Oh, Inquisitor, what kind of help do you need today?”

“Where are the records of all kinds of disasters and accidents in the city-state around the year 1889 kept?” Vanna nodded to the old priest as she asked.

“The disaster records for 1889?” the old priest muttered. He tapped a spot on the wide ring-shaped desk. At once there came a soft sound of gears rubbing under the tabletop. A section of the desktop slid down, and from inside rose a mechanical console covered with cranks, numbered dials, and little levers.

With a chorus of creaks and clicks, the old priest began to operate the clever machine with practiced ease, moving the levers and numbered dials. After

he entered the needed information, Vanna heard the deep growl that large machines made when they started to work. She felt the floor under her feet tremble a little. Countless gears and rods ran happily under the push of a steam core. Then she heard a clear ding from the device in front of the old priest, and a strip of printed paper slid out of the machine.

“Go straight along this aisle. At the third row of shelves, turn left. Walk to the end and turn right. One of the shelves there has its lights on. The row with the light is the one you want. The contents are mixed. Every event that could be called a disaster is recorded, even the smallest steam scalding accident. If you need help, just ring the bell.”

As he spoke, the old priest handed her the paper strip. He gripped it with a prosthetic hand. The brass palm and forearm had a fine mechanical structure, and through a small clear window on the back of the hand, one could see a cluster of gears ticking away inside.

Vanna thought that he was probably a Guardian veteran who had retired from the front lines. In the civil departments of the Storm Church, this kind of veteran was not rare.

Their bodies were already damaged, and they had proved their faith and loyalty with blood and sacrifice. With the help of steam-engine or magic prosthetics, they could go on serving the Holy See. Posts that dealt with files and archives became the final home for some of these veterans.

In a way, this was a kind of favor to the warriors. The archive department was fairly easy and well supplied, a place fit for them to grow old in peace. From another angle, it was also a good use of talent. The bodies of these veterans might no longer suit fighting Heretics, but their wills were still tough. And the work of guarding books and records had always needed a tough will.

A trace of respect rose in Vanna’s heart. She took the paper strip with both hands and lowered her head slightly: “Thank you.”

“When you are done, remember to put the books back properly, and do not touch any books that are not in the register,” the old priest said, waving his hand. “Many of the books here have been sitting for a very long time. Do not disturb them for no reason.”

After he finished, he returned to his “work” and paid no more attention to Vanna.

Vanna did not mind. Holding the paper strip printed with entries from the register, she walked toward the depths of the archive. On both sides of her, bookshelves so tall that she could only call them grand stood in neat rows. One after another, they reached up to the dome above, like ancient guards standing in formation and looking down at the small figures below. Bright electric lamps and carefully placed gas lamps lined the spaces between the shelves, making the place as bright as day. Even between the deepest shelves, not a single patch of dark shadows remained.

Vanna found the shelf the old priest had mentioned. A row of small bulbs lit up along it, marking the files she was allowed to read.

The files were not placed very low, but luckily Vanna was tall. She did not need a ladder to take them down, which made her feel relieved.

Pushing a ladder back and forth in such a huge library would not have been an easy job.

She took a quiet breath, found the starting point of the files on the shelf, pulled out the numbered volume, and began to read quickly.

What she wanted to find was simple: the great fire eleven years ago, or rather, the fire that had been packaged as a factory leak accident.

In fact, this was not the first time she had investigated this matter. As an Inquisitor, she was always a little sensitive to every “unusual event”, including things that happened to herself. After she learned that only she still remembered the great fire from her childhood, she had secretly looked into some records from that year. But those short and shallow searches had not given her anything useful.

At the time, she had soon put the matter out of her mind.

After all, she had been only twelve when the accident happened. She had not yet been a believer of the Goddess, and she had not had any special mind. It was not impossible for a panicked child, who had also breathed in toxic smoke, to have some false memories. There was no need to get stuck on this. So after she read a few public files, she had let the matter go.

But now she had suddenly found that someone else in the city-state of Pland had gone through the same great fire she remembered.

The doubts and countless guesses she had once pushed aside rushed back at once. Her “professional alertness” as an Inquisitor roared in her mind.

Because of this professional alertness, she had refused Heidi’s suggestion to “turn back to the antique shop” at the time. Instead, she had calmly waited until today and come straight to this archive hall, which enjoyed the Goddess’s favor, to look into the original records that were not open to the public.

The reason was simple. There was a dangerous air around this matter. Wiping away the memory of a great fire sounded easy, but in fact it touched the minds and memories of tens of thousands of people. The event had also been tied to large numbers of cultists and their acts of destruction that year. If all this had truly been the work of some “hand behind the curtain”, then that hidden hand would never sit still while someone noticed the truth.

The scraps of memory left in her own mind, the scraps left in the mind of the girl named Nina F… these “remnants” were very likely the mistakes left by that hidden hand. The one behind the scenes might not yet have noticed these mistakes, but if he did… she herself was not afraid. But Nina F and her uncle, and the girl named Shirley, were all ordinary people.

So at the time, she had refused Heidi’s suggestion and had asked Heidi not to bring the matter up again. On one hand, she did not want to alarm the enemy and wanted to investigate in secret. On the other hand, she wished to avoid dragging innocent people into danger.

Before she had enough information, she absolutely could not show any interest in that antique shop beyond what was needed.

As she slowly flipped through the file in her hands, Vanna’s thoughts rose and fell.

For some reason, the moment she sensed a shadow, she also felt as if countless unseen eyes were peeping at her and following her. That awful feeling of being watched from the dark was like thorns in her back and made her a little restless.

She put down the file and picked up the one next to it.

At the same time, she thought about the things that had happened in the city-state recently.

Many of the the Suntists active in the city had already been arrested. It seemed that the firm actions of the city-state had scared those Heretics, or perhaps all the channels they used to slip in had truly been destroyed. In any case, the number of the Suntists in the city had dropped a lot, while the Heretic prisons under the great Cathedrals were now packed full.

The goal of those the Suntists in the city-state had long since been found out.

They were searching for the “Sun fragment” that had briefly appeared eleven years ago and might still be hidden somewhere.

The Sun fragment… the great fire eleven years ago…

And the “vision” that Heidi had glimpsed earlier in the City Museum.

Vanna’s hand stopped turning the pages. Clues that had not caught her attention before suddenly linked together in her mind. As she once again examined the fire in her memory, those clues stood out even more.

The young Inquisitor took a light breath. She was now sure that these events were linked and that the great fire eleven years ago had truly happened. At the same time, her eyes drifted over some words in the file:

“…On X month, X day, in the XX block, a serious Heretic worship event occurred. Three households of residents built altars in their homes and offered blood and prayers to some unknown abomination that had never appeared in any record. This caused panic and nightmares among a large number of nearby residents. Later, the sacrificial ritual was reported and destroyed, but the clues left on site could not be linked to any known Eldritch God or Evil Spirit…

“By theory, such a ritual should not have had any effect. It should have been only the blind trial of ignorant fools, driven by their private desires. But the mass panic and nightmares among local residents did happen. Later investigation proved that the area had indeed been affected by supernatural power at that time…”

Chapter 155:

Vanna’s gaze stayed on this record for a few seconds. The sharp sense of an Inquisitor made her smell something worth notice in these short lines.

Heretic sacrificial behavior that had suddenly appeared among ordinary residents. A sacrificial target pointing to an invalid existence. A ritual that completely failed to meet any proper rules, yet in the end still drew the attention of supernatural power. A small area of mental derangement. No follow-up investigation…

Vanna suddenly thought of something. She put down the file in her hand and quickly opened a record she had looked at just now.

It had also happened in 1889, a little earlier. In a street-side shop in the Lower City, a sudden stabbing had occurred. At first, it had been a case for the security bureau and should not have appeared in the Church’s archive at all. But the later investigation showed that the attacker was a “customer” who had suddenly suffered a mental break inside the shop. The suspect insisted that he had seen blasphemous shadows on the shop window and had taken up a knife to “fight back” in order to escape the hunt of “unseen things”.

In the later investigation, the Church had found signs of Heretic worship in the shop’s basement. However, the ritual sigils at the scene were so messy that they could not point to any valid entity. Through questioning, they learned that the shop’s master, who had been doing secret ritual worship, did not understand any true occult rites at all. His clumsy sacrificial attempts had been done under “unknown guidance”.

Again, it was a messy sacrificial ritual that should not have worked in theory. Again, it had caused mental derangement in a small area. And again, there had been no further conclusion to the case.

Vanna frowned a little. These two cases seemed to have no link with the factory leak eleven years ago, or with the great fire that had been erased. The times did not match at all, and they had not been her focus today. But to see two Heretic worship cases with such clear similarity appear so close together in the records still touched her nerves as an Inquisitor.

After a moment, she put down the two files and went on searching the shelves for later records. This time, she kept some of her attention ready and actively looked for any cases that might be tied to Heretic worship.

She did not know how long had passed before she suddenly stopped.

The third record was also from a time before the “factory leak” accident. It had happened on the edge of the Upper City. A maid who worked in a rich household had suddenly gone mad. She had badly injured three servants and the male master of the house, then locked herself in a storeroom. When the Church Guardians and constables arrived and broke down the door, the maid had already taken her own life.

In the storeroom, they had found symbols of a sacrificial rite that the dead woman had carved with a dagger before she died. In her room, they had found traces of Heretic sacrifices. Once again, they pointed to another “invalid” entity, and the steps of the rite did not match any known rules. Only this time, the useless sacrificial activity had not driven others mad. It had only driven the sacrificer herself insane.

It was already the third one…

When she had seen the first two cases, Vanna had only paid a little extra attention to them. But after seeing this third record, her face had turned

completely serious.

In her mind, she quickly lined up the information from these records and began to analyze them by their time and place.

The events were very scattered. In time, they were separate. In place, they were in different areas. In theory, the people involved had no contact with each other.

None of them had much to do with the factory that had leaked eleven years ago. The later investigations had also found no trace of the Suntists in them.

Vanna calmed herself and kept searching through the later files. Not long after, she found the record of the factory leak.

It had been a major event with a very wide impact. The number of Heretics caught afterward had been the highest in twenty or thirty years. So the whole case had been given a file of its own. The thick folder was quite heavy and held many pictures and interrogation reports.

But it did not take Vanna long to read through all of it.

She had already read the same material many times in other places. In the past few years, she had looked up the records of this old case more than once.

It seemed that even here, in the archive deep inside the Cathedral, there was no more information about the factory leak eleven years ago.

Vanna put the factory file back as well and kept looking through the later records for a while. Then she suddenly noticed something:

After the “factory leak” accident, no more records of Heretic worship like the three earlier cases appeared.

The factory leak had happened in the middle of the year. There had still been a full half year afterward.

This gave Vanna a certain feeling. It was as if all those Heretic worship events that “should not have worked, yet still worked” had all crowded into the time before the factory leak. After the factory accident, it was as if they had hit a node. All Heretic worship had ended suddenly after that…

Of course, common sense could explain this too. After the factory leak, the Church and the authority had arrested thousands of cultists. That large-scale sweep had cleared the Heretic forces in the city-state. So it was quite normal that no more Heretic worship events had happened in the next half year.

But for some reason, she still felt that the logic behind these seemingly unrelated events should not be so simple.

She stopped beside the tall shelf. After thinking quietly for a long time, she went back to where she had started and pulled out the first file about Heretic worship again. She read as she thought.

These cases were far too scattered and had been buried in a heap of messy disaster records. If she had not stubbornly decided to go through everything today, and had not planted the thought of “something is wrong here” in her heart ahead of time, she might not have noticed anything strange even now. But the strange was still the strange. Once she sensed it, that feeling of wrongness grew in her like a seed taking root and sprouting, making it hard for her to ignore the warning of her instincts.

While Vanna was carefully reading the records, the sound of slow, unhurried footsteps suddenly came from nearby. With it came a faint smell of machine oil mixed with incense.

Vanna looked up and saw the old priest who managed the archive walking toward her.

He limped as he walked. Clearly, it was not only his right hand. His legs had also been hurt.

“There are not many people in the archive at this hour, so I came over to take a look,” the old priest said with a smile: “Have you found the information you wanted?”

Vanna let out a slow breath and put the file back in its place: “I found some information, but I did not find the answer I wanted.”

“An answer?” The old priest sounded a bit curious. “What kind of answer are you looking for?”

“…How long have you been here?” Vanna did not answer him directly. Instead, she suddenly asked a question that did not seem related.

“Ah, that has been a very long time. Let me think… almost twenty years now,” the old priest said with a smile. “Ever since a homemade bomb from those Heretic madmen blew off one of my hands and one of my legs, I have stayed here.”

Vanna thought for a moment, then asked with some curiosity: “Is it always this quiet here? Do other people come to read these files like I do?”

“Most of the time, it is very quiet,” the old priest said with a smile. “People do come to look up files, but not many. Books are the memory people have of the world, and this archive is the deepest part of that memory. What is stored here are old cases that have already been dealt with, or sealed files that have been judged unfit for the public. Once they are sealed, they are buried in the depths of time together with the past.

“Countless new things happen in the city-state every day. Everyone is busy walking toward tomorrow. They do not have much time to come back and turn these sealed files. And besides…”

The old priest paused for a moment. He lifted his head and quietly looked up at the shelves of books that almost reached the dome. After a long time, he spoke softly.

“And besides… sometimes the files that are sealed away are not just records of the past. Sometimes, pieces of history itself are sealed in those pages. The past, present, and future of our world all rest on an unsteady base. If you turn too many things in this archive, it is not very good for your body or your mind.”

“…That sounds a bit like the Flamebearers’ warnings.”

“Yes. The Flamebearers like to warn about things like this. They guard history. They always fear that something will spread from ancient times and corrupt the foundation of our world. They are so sensitive about it that some people even think those Enders, who shout about doomsday corruption, are Flamebearers who have fallen…”

The old priest spoke and then shook his head with a smile: “When I was young, I was close with a few friends from the Flamebearer sect, so of course I heard a lot of their theories. Their teachings are different from those of the Storm Goddess, but at least we all serve the True Gods. Some of their ideas are still worth listening to.”

For some reason, as she listened to the old man speak, Vanna’s mind slowly calmed down. She felt a bit of respect for this senior who had given most of his life to the Church, and she did not mind talking a little more with him. So she asked casually: “Do you still keep in touch with those friends?”

“No, I do not,” the old man said, shaking his head slowly. “One morning, I suddenly realized that I had never known their names. So most likely, they have already died for their faith…”

Chapter 156: The Missing Year

The old man's tone was very calm, as if he was quietly telling a story and had only happened to appear in that story for a short while.

"Sorry, once you get old you tend to talk too much," the old priest smiled and looked at Vanna as he said: "Do you have any friends from other churches?"

"…I have a friend. She is a clergy member at the Truth Academy," Vanna thought for a moment. "But she doesn't really talk to me about the teachings of the God of Wisdom Rahm."

"Ah, a believer of the God of Wisdom… That's normal. Their doctrines usually need at least a university education to understand, and sometimes you even have to pass an advanced mathematics exam," the old priest nodded as if it were only natural. "By comparison, the followers of the God of Death are much easier to deal with—after all, we are all going to die."

At this, the old man paused. He glanced with some curiosity at the neatly arranged case files behind Vanna and asked: "Inquisitor, can you tell me what you are looking for?"

Vanna suddenly hesitated.

She did not know whether she should tell this old priest about that secret. The hidden fire might point to a very dangerous shadow. She could not be sure whether that "shadow" was using some method to watch the city-state, nor could she be sure that the old man in front of her could really help. If she spoke too frankly, she might startle the snake in the grass.

But after a brief hesitation, she still decided to reveal a little.

This was the deepest part of the Deep Sea Cathedral, the sanctuary favored by the Storm Goddess. The old priest who guarded the archive hall was a resolute warrior. He stayed here to provide help to visitors in times like this.

“I am looking for a file—though calling it a file isn’t very accurate, because it might never have existed in the first place,” Vanna began slowly, choosing her words with care. “Strictly speaking, it is a lead. Something that happened in June of 1889. It may point to a great fire, but all related records have been erased.”

“A great fire in 1889?” The old priest thought for a moment. “I don’t remember any great fire…”

He suddenly stopped and looked at Vanna with a thoughtful expression.

“So the erased records also include our memories, don’t they?”

“At least they include people’s memories,” Vanna nodded lightly. “I don’t have enough evidence. Aside from my own ‘awareness’, I have no way to prove that fire ever happened. I don’t know what power is manipulating this either. I’m… only suspicious.”

She suddenly felt a little embarrassed. As an Inquisitor, she was used to doubting and investigating, but this situation was completely different from anything before. She did not even know who she was doubting, or whether that target was human or ghost. She had started an investigation based only on her own thoughts, which did not match her usual calm and steady way of doing things at all.

Yet the old priest only nodded calmly: “Your piety and your character are evidence enough, Inquisitor.”

As soon as he finished speaking, the old priest strode to a pillar between the nearby shelves and tapped several raised bumps on it with his mechanical

prosthetic hand. In the next second, a deep rumble came from under the floor, followed by the creaking and clanking of gears and linkages starting to move.

The archive's main door closed. Some of the shelves inside began to move slowly. Certain shelves slid closer together and locked into place, and in the open space that appeared, pillar after pillar rose from the floor, each one covered in intricate runes.

As the pillars rose, a faint sound of waves echoed gently in Vanna's mind.

"…There's no need to make such a big scene," Vanna felt a bit at a loss because of the old priest's actions. "This is only a preliminary investigation…"

"Past experience has taught me there is no such thing as 'preliminary' when you investigate a great threat," the old priest walked slowly back toward Vanna. He raised his brass mechanical hand and said: "And I think anything that can interfere with cognition on a large scale, even erase specific historical events, counts as a 'great threat'."

"…But sealing off the archive hall so suddenly might attract a lot of attention."

"It won't. The archive is randomly sealed several times every month so that the holy devices and shelves can 'stretch their legs' a little," the old priest laughed, showing a row of uneven teeth. "'Don't let ancient scrolls stay quiet for too long'—that's the rule."

"Then I have no more questions."

"You just went through many records. Judging from your expression, you must have found something, right?" the old priest nodded slightly. "I can help."

“I found some records of ‘heretical worship’—they are not directly related to what I’m investigating, and they are all rather scattered, but I feel something is wrong,” Vanna answered frankly. “Those heretical worship cases had common traits. They were concentrated in the first half of 1889, and they all stopped abruptly after the factory leak incident in the Sixth District…”

The old priest listened carefully to Vanna’s description, then, under her direction, found the corresponding case files.

“These are them,” Vanna pointed at the documents that had been pulled out. “Sacrificial rites that should have been ineffective, yet they caused real spiritual damage. Each case was small in scale, but every one of them was true heretical worship. All the closing reports look perfectly normal. The ones who should be arrested were arrested, and those who should be sentenced were sentenced. But I think every one of these cases… was not really investigated thoroughly.”

“For cases on this scale, catching and sentencing the offenders already counts as a complete investigation. But you are right. When several similar incidents stack together… things change,” the old priest flipped through the records and frowned. “All the people who carried out the sacrificial rites were ‘mysteriously enticed’, yet the source of that enticement could not be found…”

He muttered to himself, then suddenly looked up.

“Inquisitor, you only checked the files from 1889, correct?”

“Yes,” Vanna nodded, and then she immediately realized something. “You mean…”

“The incident you care about did indeed happen in 1889, but have you considered that these strange heretical worship cases might not have started

in 1889?” the old priest spoke quickly, then looked toward several other rows of shelves. “The earlier records are here. The lower three rows from the bottom are all available. You can read them.”

Vanna went toward those shelves at once and began to check the records together with the old priest.

After only a short time, they almost simultaneously found similar heretical worship cases in the files they were reading.

There were entries from 1888, 1887, and even back to 1886.

“There’s another record here… a sacrificial incident that happened in the Harbor District. And here, this one was only two months after the last one!”

Vanna flipped through the ledger in her hands as fast as she could, feeling her heart pounding. She looked up to tell the old priest what she had found, but suddenly noticed that the old priest was standing frozen in front of a shelf, staring at one spot without moving.

“Did you find something?” Vanna frowned at once, a little nervous.

“There are no records for 1885,” the old priest murmured softly, almost like talking to himself. “They should be here, on this row, right after 1884… But now, it jumps from 1884 straight to 1886…”

…

“Let’s stop here,” at the edge of the Sixth District, Duncan looked back toward the way he and Shirley had come and let out a small breath. “We won’t get anything more by investigating around here.”

They had spent a long time in that little church, but with the two of them together still not matching a single dog’s level in occult studies, they clearly were not enough to solve the strange Space-Time Lock in the underground sanctum.

Before they left, the underground sanctum had already returned to its original state. The nun who was caught somewhere between ashes and the living still prayed devoutly in the main hall of the church and barely reacted when Duncan and Shirley departed.

The exterior of the church was still dilapidated. The area around the building was still empty and deserted.

But Shirley no longer cared much about what secrets might be hidden inside the church.

“I… can I really go home?” she asked.

She looked at Duncan with obvious tension, and in her uneasy voice there was also a faint, hard-to-name hesitation.

“Of course you can. I have never restricted your freedom to leave,” Duncan smiled and ruffled her hair. Although Shirley was about the same age as Nina, her body was so small and thin that Duncan could not help treating her as an even younger child. “Today’s investigation is over. You can go home.”

Shirley instinctively turned her head to glance in the direction of her home. She wanted to lift her foot, but suddenly hesitated again: “Then… will we keep investigating after this?”

“Of course. This matter is far from over,” Duncan raised an eyebrow. “What is it? Are you reluctant to go?”

“Ah, n-no, no!” Shirley waved her hands at once. “I just… just mean, next time we investigate…”

“I’ll find a way to contact you, and you can come find me on your own as well,” Duncan said with another smile as he rubbed Shirley’s head. “And not just for investigations. If you run into any other trouble, you can come straight to me for help.”

Shirley blinked. She felt something was a little strange, but in the end she still nodded lightly. Before she turned to leave, she could not hold back her curiosity: “Then… what are you going to do next?”

“Me?” Duncan paused, thought for a moment, and said: “I’m going to buy a bicycle this afternoon.”

Shirley stared at him, dumbfounded: “…Huh?”

“Buy a bicycle,” Duncan repeated in all seriousness. “I promised Nina. It’s been several days already. It’s about time I kept that promise. Why, is there something wrong with that?”

Shirley opened and closed her mouth for a long time before she finally forced out a sentence: “A-Dog said you ought to at least do something that a Subspace invader is supposed to do…”

Before she even finished, a shadow suddenly leaped out of the air beside them. Dog’s hoarse voice rang out hurriedly from within the darkness: “I never said that!!”

In the next second, the shadow vanished as if it had never been there—obviously Dog was afraid someone might see him if he stayed out too long.

Duncan: “…”

He held back for a long time before he finally managed a helpless smile: “All right, then. The Subspace invader is going to buy his niece a bicycle now—we part ways here.”

Chapter 157: The Captain’s Big Shopping Trip

Duncan had meant what he said—after he said goodbye to Shirley, he really did go to the shops near the Crossroad District to buy a bicycle for Nina.

At the same time, he planned to finally do something he had long intended to do but had been delaying again and again: open a bank account for himself.

Inside the Pland City-State Bank, Duncan sat waiting while the clerk at the front counter prepared the last form for him. Waiting was dull, so he let his attention wander as he observed his surroundings.

Perhaps because it was not a rest day, and also because few citizens from the Lower City needed to handle banking business, the hall felt rather empty. The hall itself was not very large, and of the five service windows, three were idle. Staff in black uniforms chatted idly behind the unused windows. Bright electric lamps shone on the glass of the counters, casting a lazy sheen.

Duncan’s gaze moved upward. He saw long cast-iron pipes rising from behind those counters. The pipes went straight up like slender pillars into the ceiling, then ran neatly in parallel and extended somewhere behind the hall. A deep, rhythmic clicking came from under the floor, as if some mechanical system was running down below.

The clerk who was preparing his forms finally confirmed the last item. She handed the papers to Duncan and said in a routine tone: “Please check that

everything is correct, then sign at the bottom. Your account number and seal pattern are on there. The handling fee for a bearer account is 6 sola and 5 peso."

Duncan took the form and looked over the contents with interest. His mind filled at once with guesses about the city-states' civilization and their economic system, but he was no expert in such things. After letting his thoughts wander for a short while, he focused on the end of the form. He memorized the short string of numbers there, signed his name, and handed the form and the fee back across the counter.

The clerk took the form, glanced at it casually, then placed it on a punch-card machine. With a crisp series of clicks, the punch-card machine punched a dense array of holes into the blank margin along the edge. Then she rolled up the form, stuffed it into a metal cylinder, and fed it into one of the pipes beside the counter.

There was a metallic clank. The pipe sealed itself. The hiss of steam pressure and the sound of something speeding along inside the pipe reached Duncan's ears. His eyes followed the sound upward and saw one of the curved pipes near the ceiling tremble slightly—the document had been sent somewhere far away.

"Please wait a bit," the clerk behind the counter said casually. "If the pipes are working properly today and the machine at the other end happens to be in good condition too, you'll get your receipt within half an hour. But if that fault light over there comes on, you'll have to come back tomorrow."

It was a peculiar process.

To Duncan, the efficiency seemed nothing special. But to this world, this was already the advanced achievement of city-state civilization in the Deep Sea era.

He watched everything with a mix of curiosity and emotion, and at the same time he heard the clerks chatting.

A young man at the next window was sighing: “I heard the Truth Academy is talking with the main branch. They want to install some kind of new machine that can boost the main branch’s processing efficiency by several times…”

“That’s called a large Sorting Engine. The city-state bank in Morka has been using them for a long time. There are some in Pland too. The tax office and the mathematics institute each have a few smaller ones. The Great Cathedral has one as well. I heard it’s used to manage their archives,” the clerk sitting opposite Duncan joined in without thinking. “If you ask me, the main branch is only thinking about this now. They’re slow enough as it is.”

“That has nothing to do with us anyway,” another bored clerk joined the conversation. “Those things are expensive and heavy. When you count the steam core that drives them and the supporting punch-card machines and Analytical Engines, a single Sorting Engine can fill this entire hall…”

“I heard the Truth Academy is gathering people to research the next generation of Sorting Engines too. Supposedly they’ll be half the size of the current big ones, with performance almost the same, and they run on electricity instead of steam…”

“Electricity? No steam core? What if the machine gets possessed while it’s running? Those things have to keep crunching huge amounts of data. Without Divine Steam to protect it, malevolent spirits would be drawn to the bearings and gear trains way too easily, don’t you think?”

“How would I know… Maybe they’ll have a priest stand next to it. The machine computes, and the priest burns incense and holds mass for it at the same time…”

“…That doesn’t sound like it saves much trouble. It just adds another member of the clergy to the setup…”

“Hey, how much space does a priest take, and how much space does half a Sorting Engine take? Have you seen real estate prices in the city center?”

It seemed that no matter the world, people’s idle chatter at work drifted in the same wild directions. The clerks’ talk soon shifted from Sorting Engines to housing prices in the city, but from Duncan’s point of view, everything they chatted about was fresh and fascinating. He listened with such interest that he even forgot the boredom of waiting.

The idle talk did not last long. With a loud clank from one of the nearby pipes, their discussion about “which is more expensive, priests or housing” finally came to an end.

The clerk opposite Duncan opened the brass tube next to the counter and took out a small metal cylinder from inside. This one was clearly a different model from the one sent out earlier. It was heavier, and the cap was sealed with a complicated locking mechanism. The clerk spent a while working at it with a special tool before the lid finally came off, revealing the item inside.

It was a rectangular metal plate, only about half the size of a palm. Letters and symbols had been stamped into it, and along its edges there were rows of randomly arranged holes of different sizes. The short string of numbers Duncan had just memorized was stamped at one end.

“This is your bank seal card,” the clerk said as she handed the metal plate to Duncan. “It can be used at any bank in the city-state of Pland, and at the Boundless Sea Chamber of Commerce banks in other city-states as well. But deposits and withdrawals in other city-states will be delayed three to seven days. That’s the time needed for transoceanic telegraphs or Spirit Realm communications.”

“Thank you.” Duncan took the metal plate and examined this device that seemed to represent the city-state’s level of technology. His eyes studied the fine little holes, and on the counter he noticed the machine that read these metal plates.

These devices, so different from anything on Earth and yet just as much a product of human thought, were the “footprints” left by city-state civilization on its march through the Deep Sea era.

“Do you have any other business today?” the voice from behind the counter asked.

“Ah… nothing else, thank you,” Duncan came back to himself. He smiled, stood up from the chair, and then, just as he was about to leave, he seemed to remember something. He stopped and asked casually: “By the way… can machines really get possessed?”

“Of course they can. Why is that strange?” the clerk replied at once, as if it were something she did not even need to think about. “In this world, everything except Subspace can be corrupted. Isn’t that common knowledge?”

Duncan paused for a moment. He had asked only out of idle curiosity, but for some reason her answer touched his thoughts. He felt a faint spark in the depths of his mind.

After a short silence, he nodded slowly: “…Right. In this world, everything except Subspace can be corrupted.”

Then he left the bank.

According to his plan, he still had a big shopping trip to complete today. Besides buying a bicycle for Nina, his shopping list held a pile of things that would probably scare Nina half to death if she saw it written out.

The money from selling that dagger to Old Mr. Morris, plus the bounty for reporting the cultists, was enough to support a family of three living comfortably in the Lower City for one or two years. Most of that money was still untouched. Duncan felt it was time to put it to use.

So during the next half day, Duncan practically swept through the markets and shops near the Crossroad District…

Around four in the afternoon, in the shadow of an alley near the Crossroad District, Duncan set down the last bundle with a clatter and let out a long breath.

He looked with satisfaction at the pile of goods stacked like a small hill in front of him.

Flour, vegetables, seeds, spices, fresh meat, preserved foods, dried mushrooms of all kinds, wine—and cheese.

Edible, normal cheese that was younger than he was.

There were also piles of pots and pans and all sorts of things that Duncan thought “might come in handy.”

Once he moved all this onto the ship, the living conditions on the Vanished would change dramatically.

At the very least, the kitchen could start producing proper human food on a regular basis.

Duncan nodded in satisfaction and called out casually: “AI!”

The flutter of wings came from above the nearby buildings, and AI landed neatly on his shoulder.

The next second, the pigeon glanced at the pile on the ground and squawked in horror: “Are you making fun of me?!”

Before it even finished its shout, the bird rolled sideways and let itself drop toward the ground. Duncan had not actually said what he wanted it to do yet, but the creature had clearly, and very cleverly, realized what was coming.

Duncan only chuckled, reached out, and caught the pigeon in midair as it fell: “It’s fine. If you can’t carry it all in one trip, you can always make a few more runs…”

Chapter 158: Rose Doll House

To be honest, the pile of stuff in the little alley was not actually that big. After all, Duncan was working alone. Even though he had bought a bicycle ahead of time to haul goods, there was still a limit to how much he could move at once. AI's reaction was actually very easy to understand—

The bird was bargaining. It wanted more fries.

From a certain point of view, this bird was just too easy to read.

"Do you know what this is?" Duncan grabbed the pigeon and held it in front of a basket of potatoes. "This is called a potato, also called a tuber."

AI blinked its little green pea eyes and stared at the basket for a long time. It actually reacted. It stretched its neck hard and cried: "Smells so good! So good!"

"As long as you know. Do your work properly. This whole basket is for you—once it's all fried into fries, it'll be enough to stuff you to death dozens of times over." Duncan chuckled, then casually tossed the pigeon away. "Send this stuff back to the Vanished—just put it straight on the deck. 'I' will meet you there."

AI flapped its wings in the air. Before it even landed, a mass of ghostly green fire wrapped around it. It turned into an Undead bird and circled the pile of goods twice. The "cargo" inside the flames started to fade rapidly. But then it suddenly stopped, landed on the pile, and tilted its head at Duncan: "Do I need to specify the next memory address?"

Duncan stared for a long moment before he realized the bird was asking what he wanted done next…

Then he could not help grumbling inside. This bird's vocabulary was way too huge and weird. It was like everything Earth humans had ever made up on the internet was stored in its head. After spending this much time together, Duncan could more or less guess what it meant from context, but most of the time his conversations with AI were brushing right up against the edge of his own knowledge.

Could it not try learning how to talk like a normal person?

But grumbling was grumbling. Duncan still nodded and answered AI: "Send these off first. I still need to go buy some more…"

This time AI was really scared. It shot straight up, and in the blink of an eye a big ball of fire swept away everything piled on the ground. As it vanished from Duncan's sight, it shouted loudly: "So terrifying! So terrifying!"

Duncan only shrugged at this, then turned and walked over to the bicycle he had just bought.

It was a very ordinary bicycle. It had a black frame, shiny silver rims and handlebars, a brand-new bell, and a sturdy, practical basket and rear rack. It had no special features. It was not beautiful, but not ugly either. Its biggest advantage was probably that the quality was pretty good.

At first, Duncan had wanted to pick out a pretty ladies' bicycle for Nina. But after going through all the shops in the Lower City, he gave up on that idea—because there simply were none.

In the Lower City, a bicycle was just a bicycle. It was a tool that helped with daily life, but even more a tool of production. All the bikes looked more or less the same. There were no fancy categories like men's models, ladies' models, mountain bikes, or road bikes. People of different sizes

could just adjust the handlebars and seat to ride more easily. Other than that, the bicycle had no special function or “positioning.”

Most ordinary people in this world did not seem to have the spare energy to chase or customize a “more refined life.”

In these city-states of the “Deep Sea era,” a lot of things were still different from the “other world” that Duncan knew. Even if they looked similar on the surface, the details were always filled with this world’s own special traits. And it was exactly these almost-but-not-quite details that kept reminding Duncan that he was “living abroad.”

He swung himself onto the bike. This brand-new way to get around was light and easy to use. It carried him quickly out of the alley and toward the busier commercial streets not far away.

Nina would like this bicycle.

Leaving the Crossroad District and heading northwest, riding up toward higher streets, he truly entered the range of the Upper City. Normally, the citizens of Pland called this place “the line where real respectable life begins,” unlike the Crossroad District, which only counted as “a stage where the middle-class citizens dressed themselves up.”

Unlike what Duncan had first imagined, even though Pland had a clear administrative border between the Upper City and the Lower City, there was no physical wall between the two. To go from the Lower City to the Upper City, you just needed to pass through a few completely open junctions. These junctions did have constable booths set up, but they clearly did not stop citizens from moving back and forth.

Of course, that was only during the day. From what Duncan had heard, after nightfall, strict travel bans were enforced between the Upper City and the

Lower City. Even if you had a night pass, you still needed extra paperwork to cross the checkpoints between the two districts.

Right now, it was daytime. The junctions were wide open.

Duncan rode straight into the Upper City. Ever since he had arrived in this city-state, this was his first time visiting this area.

He had to admit, the Upper City really was a completely different place from the Lower City.

You could see it in almost every aspect—cleaner and wider streets, taller and grander buildings, newer and more advanced city facilities, and gas street lamps and “nighttime Sanctuary Worlds” in numbers that clearly far surpassed the Lower City.

Duncan slowly stopped his bike in front of a little kiosk near a junction.

It was a nighttime Sanctuary World, meant to help citizens who, for one reason or another, failed to make it home in time after nightfall. A sign by the door listed a brief explanation:

“Provides shelter for the night. Inside there is a gas lamp, calming holy oil, and the Storm Canon. After entering, please lock the door and wait for rescue. The Night Watch Guard holds the key.”

Duncan had also seen similar facilities in the Lower City. But in a whole block there might be only one or two, and they looked old and worn. It was hard to tell if they still worked.

He pulled back his gaze, got back on his bike, and continued slowly down the street.

From time to time, his eyes swept over the shops lining the road.

The bright windows and carefully arranged, elegant displays were something the shops in the Lower City could not compare with. But Duncan

was not focused on these unimportant details.

He still had a lot to buy. Stocking supplies for the Vanished was something that had been put off for too long. And…

Duncan stopped the bicycle and raised his head to look at a shop by the street. A small smile appeared on his face.

Some things simply could not be bought in the Lower City—only the "respectable people" of the Upper City were willing to spend so much money and energy on things not related to survival. For example, the place right in front of him.

He locked his bicycle, stepped forward, and pushed open the shop door. With the clear, pleasant sound of a bell, a plump old lady behind the counter put down her newspaper and looked up. A kind smile spread over her face as she stood and said: "Welcome to the Rose Doll House… Oh, a gentleman. Are you here to choose a companion for your lover or a junior in your family?"

"I'll just look around first." Duncan answered simply, then raised his head and curiously looked around this shop called the "Rose Doll House."

Everywhere he looked, there were dolls—delicate, elegant, mysterious, cute, playful… dolls of all kinds.

Back on the street, he had already seen the shop through the window. But only when he stepped inside did he realize the interior was even bigger than it seemed from outside. Almost every visible space was packed with doll-related things. Even the space under the stairs was filled with different storage boxes and stands, plus all sizes of accessories and blank "bodies" waiting to be assembled.

This was a shop that specialized in selling dolls and doll-related items. Its style was classical, and it had a quiet, mysterious atmosphere.

And in this big doll shop, there was only one kindly looking old madam watching the place. At the moment, Duncan was also the only customer.

An old-fashioned shop full of dolls. A smiling old lady. A single customer.

Duncan’s attention was drawn by the dazzling array of dolls, while the shop’s master watched this strange guest with a bit of curiosity.

It was not rare for men to visit doll shops. Respectable gentlemen in the Upper City often bought fine dolls as gifts for their partners or juniors, and some men themselves loved collecting dolls. What really made the old shopkeeper curious was not the customer’s gender, but his plain, simple clothes.

Duncan wore the same worn-out coat he usually wore. It did not look like the clothing of a rich man who lived in the Upper City—and dolls were not cheap collectibles.

But the old lady only glanced at him out of curiosity and soon looked away.

It was not polite to judge a customer by his clothes. A seasoned businesswoman should not judge guests by their appearance. Besides, everyone had the right to appreciate the goods.

After looking around for a while, Duncan finally pulled his gaze back and let out a quiet breath.

He had to admit, he was a bit overwhelmed.

The doll craft in this world was more advanced than he had imagined. All those strange “parts,” so many that he could not even name them all, had already gone beyond his understanding of what a doll was.

His understanding of a “doll” was a useless crew member who was timid, weak, had a bad neck, and not much of a brain.

Duncan looked at the chubby old madam and decided he should humbly ask a professional about the ways of dolls—especially about maintaining joints and putting in hair.

But before he could speak, he suddenly froze.

He stared blankly at the old lady in front of him. She quickly noticed, smiled, and pointed at her own ear: “Elves from the city-state of Pland are indeed rare.”

Duncan: “…”

He admitted, the Elves of Pland might really be rare. This was also the first time in his life he had ever seen an Elf.

But the bigger reason he was stunned was that he had never expected there to be a chubby, middle-aged Elf old madam in this world…

Chapter 159: Who Isn’t Bullying Who

After the Deep Sea era began, the sapient races that survived from the Old World and built up city-state civilizations were not just humans. Other than humans, there were also the @#?%, the Senkin, and the Elves—three other races that lived in this world and developed their own cultures.

This was written in Nina’s textbooks. Duncan had known it long ago. From very early on, he had been extremely interested in these “nonhuman races” mentioned in the books, especially the Elves. This race, always appearing in all kinds of fantasy stories and wrapped in a mysterious halo, actually existed in this world. That had once made his curiosity explode.

The pictures in Nina’s textbooks described how Elves looked. The illustration was the same as the Elves in his own imagination. They had long pointed ears, tall and slender bodies, beautiful faces so pretty it was hard to tell if they were male or female.

This made him build up a first impression of Elves in this world: a long-lived species with lifespans of a thousand years, generally very good-looking, elegant, and mysterious.

But in this shallow first impression, he had never pictured what long-lived Elves would look like when they grew old. He had not even thought this race would have visible changes in appearance after aging, just like humans.

Now he understood that his idea of “Elves” in this world had been far too shallow.

The shopkeeper of this “Rose Doll House” was an Elf—a plump, kindly smiling Elf old lady. Aside from the pointed ears and green eyes, and the faint trace of the beauty she had had in her youth, she did not look much different from any ordinary, neighborly old madam.

Staring at others was impolite.

Duncan reacted quickly. He pulled back his overly curious gaze and rubbed his chin a bit awkwardly: “This is the first time I’ve seen an Elf.”

He was not worried that his “ignorance” would expose anything. Elves truly were rare in the city-state of Pland.

Each race had its own city-states. Because travel was hard in the Deep Sea era, most commoners hardly ever left their homeland in their entire lives. Only brave deep-sea explorers and trade caravans traveled between city-states, and even they were only passing through. They almost never settled down in a city-state of another race. All the city-states were like this. More than ninety-nine percent of the residents were of the “main race.”

A person who lived in their own city and rarely went out might never see the “nonhuman folk” living on the other side of the city in their whole life.

“That’s very normal,” the Elf old madam said with a laugh. “All the Elves in this city put together probably don’t even reach a hundred. And that count includes the dozen shut-ins at the mathematics institute who have been holed up there for two hundred years and never go out. Is there something I can help you with?”

Hearing her reminder, Duncan remembered what he had come for. He glanced back at all the dolls filling the windows, counters, and stairway space, and said while thinking: “I want to buy some things for a doll. And if

possible, I'd also like to ask some questions about dolls… but as soon as I came in, I got overwhelmed."

"Oh, looks like you're a 'beginner.'" The old lady nodded. "Is it a female doll? Is it for your own collection, or…?"

"Female, my own 'collection,'" Duncan answered without thinking. Right after he said it, he felt something was off and the corner of his mouth twitched. "This hobby isn't strange, is it?"

It had been fine until he asked that. Asking made it sound even stranger…

"Of course it's not strange. Collecting and caring for dolls is a tasteful interest." The old lady did not seem surprised at all. Maybe that was the calm that came from running a shop that had been around for several hundred years. "Are you planning to buy clothes for your doll, or accessories?"

Duncan thought for a moment: "Let's start with a wig…"

"This way." The old lady led Duncan to a corner of the shop, then asked: "What size is the doll? One-quarter? Or one-third?"

Duncan said: "…The same size as a real person."

The old lady's steps paused without her meaning to. She turned back: "That… is rare. A doll the same size as a person? It must be very valuable."

"…I'm not really sure how much she is 'worth.'" Duncan tried to hold back his own discomfort and kept a straight face. "Someone gave her to me…"

"Then it seems you have a very generous friend." The old lady smiled. As she spoke, she opened a wooden box near the ring-shaped counter and laid its contents out on the counter beside it. "Large dolls are rare, and matching parts are even rarer. Everything we have is here—there are wigs and hair accessories."

Duncan coughed twice and muttered as he leaned closer: “I don’t really know if he’s generous or not. He’s a captain… it’s a complicated story.”

His eyes fell on the things the old lady had taken out.

They were finely made and well cared for. It was clear the maker had put a lot of effort into them.

He chose carefully, trying to imagine what Alice would look like wearing these things. But halfway through the picture in his mind, he could not continue.

The thought that the elegant, beautiful, and mysterious cursed doll would one day go bald and have to live relying on a wig was such a huge mismatch that even he himself could hardly accept it.

And he was the one who came up with the idea.

But soon Duncan hardened his heart. Since he had already started bullying her, he might as well carry it all the way. With that mindset, he picked one that looked pleasing to the eye…

A lavish golden wig, with matching silver hair ornaments.

Yes, silver hair ornaments. As a kind of luxury item only the upper classes had access to, doll accessories were not cheap at all.

Looking at the wig set in front of him, Duncan could not help imagining how Alice would react when she received it. That silly girl might clutch her head and cry, or she might turn and run, just like anyone who had to face their fate when it came to hair loss. It would take a bit of mental adjustment. But no matter how Alice reacted then, he himself was already starting to feel happy now.

While picking things out, he casually said: “By the way, can I ask about some ways to maintain and care for dolls?”

“Of course.” The old lady smiled kindly. “Dolls need careful attention.”

“It’s like this… What should I do if a doll’s joints keep coming loose?” Duncan spoke while acting it out with his hands. “Mainly the part where the neck connects to the head. It’s a ball joint, and for some reason it got loose. Her head keeps falling off.”

“Damage and deformation of the ball and the socket will both cause a joint to loosen. If it’s not because of poor care later or rough handling, then the design or material probably wasn’t good from the start,” the old lady answered at once. “If it’s already at the point where the head often falls off, normal repair won’t help much. You could think about replacing the whole joint.”

She thought for a moment, then added: “But replacing the joints on a large doll is not easy. You might not be able to do it yourself. You can bring the doll here. I can help replace the joint—we only charge for the parts.”

After listening, Duncan thought it over and decided this did not sound very reliable.

Alice’s “guillotine” ability was actually the smaller problem. The main issue was that Anomaly 099 was not an ordinary doll! Could her joints even be replaced?

If he told her they had to go into the city and operate on her, take her whole neck apart and put in a new one, she would probably turn and run on the spot…

So Duncan brushed past that topic and moved on to asking about techniques for putting new hair into dolls…

The old shopkeeper patiently explained many things. After she finished, she added: “…From what you said, your doll is the kind that came with its own hair. For this kind of doll, if you try to re-root or add hair later, unless the

original maker does it in person, it is very hard to reach a perfect result. And since you also said her head joint already has problems, I suggest you have a new head sculpt made for her directly…"

Duncan: "…"

The old shopkeeper was quite enthusiastic: "You don't really want to, judging by your reaction? Don't worry. Our craftsmanship here has always been top notch. In several hundred years, we have never disappointed a customer. Not a single old client has ever complained…"

Duncan thought that all those "old clients" of hers probably did not even have bones left now, so of course none of them could come back to complain. But he definitely could not say that out loud. He could only give an awkward smile and grab at the first excuse he could find: "That's not it. It's just that… if the head is replaced, then she wouldn't be her anymore, right?"

He had only said it casually, but he did not expect the old lady's eyes to light up at once. Even her smile became more sincere than before: "Ah, that way of thinking is not simple at all. Many people only see dolls as objects. Even when they love them, very few think the way you do."

Duncan suddenly felt a bit embarrassed: "Ahem, now that you say that, I feel a little shy…"

"I'm telling the truth." The old shopkeeper sighed. "Dolls need to be cared for with your heart. From the moment they are given human form, they should no longer be treated as dead things. There is a saying among doll makers—dolls that are treated with care have their own souls. You should even believe that they have their own joy, anger, sorrow, and happiness."

At once, the image of Alice's harmless "hehe" smile popped up in Duncan's mind. He nodded again and again: "You're right. You're right."

Chapter 160: The Most Outstanding Dollmaster

On the Vanished, bright sunlight shone on the freshly scrubbed upper deck. A spiral of green flame was slowly fading in the air above the planks. Alice stood by the open space, staring wide-eyed at the huge pile of things that had appeared on the deck.

“Th-this… what is all this?!”

Miss Doll cried out in shock. Before her voice even faded, Duncan’s voice came from not far away: “You’re stuttering like your head just fell off – have you never seen pots, pans, fruit, and vegetables?”

Alice turned her head a little stiffly. She glanced at Duncan, then at the big pile of supplies that had suddenly appeared on the deck. She thought hard for a moment, then planted her hands on her hips with perfect confidence. “Never!”

Duncan: “…?”

“I haven’t,” Alice went on, still very sure of herself. “I’ve stayed in that box all these years. Where would I have seen these things?”

Duncan froze for a second, then slapped his forehead. “…I forgot. All right, you’re right. In some ways, you’re even more illiterate than Shirley.”

Alice had been about to step forward and study what all the things that AI had just teleported over were for. When she heard Duncan’s words, she turned back with suspicion. “Shirley? Who is that?”

“Someone I met in the city-state. Maybe one day in the future you’ll have a chance to meet her,” Duncan said after thinking for a moment. “I feel the two of you are quite fated.”

“Oh.” Alice made a sound and soon tossed the matter to the back of her mind. She walked over to the big pile of supplies on the deck and circled around it again and again.

“So this is flour… This is meat? It really isn’t the same as the dried meat on the ship… These are vegetable leaves? They feel so fragile, and cold… This round thing is – ah, it broke…”

“Stop messing with the eggs!” Duncan saw that this clueless Doll was about to cause more trouble again. He hurried over and slapped away her hands that were poking at everything. “I’m using all this to improve life on the ship.”

“Hehe…” Alice let out her trademark laugh and pulled back her hands, a little embarrassed. “I’m just curious – I’ve only ever heard of most of these things.”

Duncan gave the Doll a helpless look, but he also understood her somewhat.

Alice’s head (if she really had that organ in her skull) held a lot of “innate knowledge”. She knew how to talk with people and knew that many things existed in the world. She had even formed her first impression of the world by using the Listening rite to listen to the sounds outside the box. But she had always been sealed away. Strictly speaking, she had only truly come into contact with this world not long ago. And the first thing she encountered was the Vanished, a stage absolutely unfit to be a beginner’s village.

She knew far too little about the Mortal Realm.

For a while before this, the only things she could touch were the things on the Vanished. The ship's limited space and objects were still easy enough for her to adapt to. But now, Duncan had dumped in front of this Doll a whole heap of new things from the Human city-state.

Even a leaf of greens or a bag of flour was an unbelievable object to Alice.

"Human city-states really are incredible places…" Miss Doll looked at the pile of things on the deck and at the colorful packages. She spoke with heartfelt wonder. "They must be much, much bigger than the ship, right?"

"…Very big, but still much smaller than the Boundless Sea." Duncan answered casually. He let his gaze rest on Alice's eyes, which were full of surprise and expectation, and once again remembered what he had promised her.

He had said that he would take Alice to see the city-state.

"I'll deal with the trouble over there as soon as I can, and I'll figure out the secret about you," he said very seriously to the Doll in front of him. "For now, you just have to wait patiently."

Alice's face instantly bloomed into a bright smile. "All right."

She still looked as carefree as ever.

Yet just looking at this carefree Doll slowly eased the anxiety Duncan had built up in Pland. He let out a small breath and pointed at the things on the deck. "Help me carry them all to the galley – and that pile of odds and ends next to them goes to the captain's cabin."

"Oh, okay!" Alice agreed at once. As she stepped forward to help, she asked, "Are we going to use these to make tonight's dinner?"

Duncan looked back at her, doubtful. "We can… but do you know how?"

“Of course not!” Alice said as if this was perfectly natural. “But I can ask Mr. Goathead for advice. He said his cooking is amazing and he has mastered more than ninety percent of the cooking secrets in the world…”

“He dares say that and you actually believe him!” Duncan’s eyes widened at once. “Don’t you dare ruin the ingredients I worked so hard to get. I’ll make dinner. If you really want to seriously learn how to cook food people can eat, just watch how I do it. Don’t learn from that Goathead – he doesn’t even have a digestive tract.”

“Oh…” Alice nodded, then glanced at AI, who was pacing on the deck nearby. Her eyes turned. “Is AI going ‘over there’ again later?”

“Of course. There are more things for it to deliver later.”

“You’re still buying things?” Alice asked curiously. “What else are you going to buy?”

Duncan turned his head and let his gaze rest on Miss Doll’s eyes. After a moment, a faint smile appeared on his face.

“I’m buying things for you.”

Alice: “…?”

…

In the city-state of Pland, inside the Rose Doll House.

Duncan felt that this kindly old Elf madam had probably misunderstood him, but he had no intention of explaining.

Most of all, he had no way to explain. How was he supposed to tell her that there really was a Doll in his home who had a soul and her own joys and sorrows, and that this Doll had lately been worried about her hair getting thinner and thinner? If he said that, the old madam would probably go report him to the Cathedral even in the best case…

But in the eyes of the Rose Doll House's shopkeeper, Duncan had already become a true kindred spirit who genuinely loved Dolls and was willing to pour a lot of effort into them. In Pland's upper society, many people bought Dolls, and quite a few were truly keen collectors. But very few people showed such heartfelt concern for a Doll as this Mr. did today. It gave her the feeling that when he spoke of his "Doll", he was not talking about an "object" at all, but about a living person, even a "friend" this Mr. cared very much about.

Even many Dollmasters did not have such an attitude.

The two of them talked very happily. Duncan finally heard many things about Dolls from the mouth of a professional, though he did not know how much of this knowledge could actually be used on Alice. The gallery's shopkeeper clearly had not met such a like-minded customer in a long time. After a good talk, the old madam could not help but smile and sigh.

"I've lived in this city for three or four hundred years. I've outlasted seventeen governors, and the Humans I've met are beyond counting – yet almost none of them truly understand 'Dolls'… Ah, you may not like hearing this, but in my eyes, Humans really are a species much colder than Elves."

"I don't know much about Elven society," Duncan said at once when he heard this, seizing the chance to guide her into talking more about Elves. "But I've heard that in the Elven city-state of Lightwind Harbor, the finest craftsmen in the world gather there. The Elves' unique crafts are famous all over the world…"

"Elves are indeed good at delicate crafts. We are a race naturally sensitive to both mathematics and art – so most of the famous Dollmasters in this world are Elves as well," the old woman said frankly, her tone filled with a natural pride. But she quickly changed the topic. "But when it comes to the

Dollmaster trade, many colleagues from other races hold a prejudice against Elves… People often say that Elves don't really have such a great talent for craft. The reason we can produce so many Dollmasters is only because our lives are long enough, and we grind the skill out bit by bit…"

Duncan suddenly did not know how to pick up this topic. "Well… all right, colleagues are enemies. Seems it's the same everywhere. What do you think of those comments?"

The old woman laughed. "Me? I think they're right!"

Duncan: "…?"

"I think they're right," the old woman repeated, her face full of a cheerful smile. "Every Undead Festival, I go to the graves of a few old colleagues to say hello and tell them, 'You were right' – if they have the ability, they can get up and hit me!"

Duncan: "…"

Were all the Elves in this world like this? Why did he feel that something about this style was off?!

"Ah… just joking," the old woman finally shook her head, probably having noticed the look on Duncan's face. "There aren't really so many enemies. We all just act as each other's companions for a short stretch of time. And if we really talk about this Dollmaster trade… I've always felt that the most outstanding Dollmaster in this world is not any 'Master' among the Elves, but a Human."

"A Human?" Duncan asked casually.

"Yes. ordinary persons nowadays probably don't know this name anymore…" The old woman spoke slowly, with a hint of feeling. "Her name is Lucretia Abnomar. She is the daughter of that famous 'Captain Duncan'. She was the most outstanding Dollmaster I have ever seen…"

Duncan: “?!”

Chapter 161: Another Layer of Connection

In the eyes of the Rose Doll House's shopkeeper, the most outstanding Dollmaster in this world was a Human named Lucretia Abnomar, the daughter of the famous "Captain Duncan".

As soon as the old madam said this, the entire shop fell silent for several seconds. Then Duncan's earth-shaking cough finally broke out. "Cough, cough, cough…"

"Guest, are you all right?" The shopkeeper was startled by Duncan's reaction. Like every Elf who had dealt with short-lived races for many years, her face at once showed the worry that the Human in front of her might suddenly drop dead. "Do you need me to fetch a doctor?"

"Cough… I… cough, I'm fine," Duncan finally managed to stop coughing. It still took him a moment before he could wave a hand at the old madam in front of him, because at the same time he also had to calm the cursed Doll on the Vanished, who had just been frightened by him. "I just choked on my own saliva. What did you just say? Lucreti…"

"Lucretia Abnomar, Mistress of the Radiant Star, one of Captain Duncan's two children," the shopkeeper said, wearing an expression that clearly said, "This all happened in just the last few decades. Why are you Humans so easily shocked?" "The most outstanding Dollmaster in the world…"

Duncan had just managed to catch his breath, but when he heard the old madam's words, another mouthful of saliva went straight into his lungs.

“Pft -”

At the same time, on the deck of the Vanished, Alice, who had just been frightened by Duncan’s violent coughing, was startled again by his shout of “Bloody hell!”. Miss Doll, holding a big basket of vegetables and fruit, stared at the captain, who was acting strangely today. “Are you all right?”

“I’m fine,” Duncan said after taking a breath, calming himself little by little. He had finally learned, after this period of practice, to control his two bodies skillfully, and now he had almost become flustered again. To keep from acting too strange in the city-state, he first waved at the Doll in front of him. “Go back to the cabin on your own for now. I have something to deal with.”

“Are you really all right?” Alice still looked over with doubt, Duncan’s face reflected in her pale violet eyes. “Do you want me to check your body, maybe pat your back so your breath will go down…”

“Do you know how?”

“Nope.”

“Then go, go, go!”

“Oh.”

After finally shooing away the silly Doll, Duncan quickly focused his attention back on the city-state of Pland. He raised his eyes and looked very seriously at the slightly plump old Elf madam in front of him. “That famous Captain Duncan… he is that legendary captain of the Vanished…”

“Shh, don’t just say that name out loud!” The shopkeeper quickly cut him off. “ordinary persons like you don’t know. If you casually speak the name of such a Great Terror and great curse, misfortune will cling to you! Be careful or that ship will come into your dreams!”

“…You’re right,” Duncan choked for a moment, forced down the strange feeling in his heart, and nodded. “That captain… not only has a daughter named Lucretia, but also has two children?”

“Yes. That was a hundred years ago. I’ve even seen the two of them. The son is named Tyrian Abnomar. Later he served as some kind of general under the Frostholm queen, but not long after that there was a rebellion in Frostholm. The kid took a group of people and became a pirate. The daughter is Lucretia Abnomar, the most outstanding Dollmaster…”

The old madam rambled on, then paused and sighed again. “But all that was many years ago, at least many years for Humans… In Pland, few people mention them anymore. Even in the Elven city-states, people do not dare speak casually about things related to that ship. But what is there to fear? Those two siblings were not like their father, who went mad. They are still fine and serving as captains now…”

“Wait!” Duncan’s eyes widened at once. “You’re saying the two of them are still alive?!”

“Alive, yes. They are said to be cursed by Subspace with undying immortality,” the old madam sighed. “They will probably live even longer than I will…”

Duncan: “…”

“Guest, are you really all right?” The shopkeeper, the old madam, finally could not help asking again. “Your face hasn’t looked right for a while. Do you dislike this topic? That’s normal. Most Humans don’t like to hear me say these things. They don’t even dare listen in broad daylight…”

“I dare listen, I dare,” Duncan came back to himself at that and quickly straightened his expression and posture. He almost stared burning holes into

the shopkeeper in front of him. “Tell me a bit more about those two siblings. And you just said… you’ve seen both of them?”

“A century ago,” the old woman said slowly, with a tone of remembrance. “I was already running a shop on this street then. The two siblings came to buy things from me. Lucretia bought a one-third-scale Doll, and Tyrian paid. They were still young then, and their father… was still a normal Human. Oh, let’s not mention him. We can’t mention him.”

“Then more than ten years later, on the road to Lunsa to meet with colleagues, I saw Lucretia alone again. By then she had already become an outstanding Dollmaster and artificer… Her clockwork-driven automata were things even I could not make…”

The shopkeeper started rambling again, talking about stories that would already count as history for most Humans, but were only parts of a life of memories to her.

It seemed that no matter the race, older people liked to reminisce and ramble like this. Once someone gave them a start, such topics never ended.

Duncan’s feelings were still surging like waves, but his face was already calm. He listened carefully to every word the old woman said and stored all this shocking information in his mind without missing a single piece.

For the ordinary persons in the city-states, the cursed captain from a century ago and his cursed children could only be a distant story. But for an Elf who had lived here for several centuries, many so-called “secret histories” were just things she had seen in her early years. She spoke of many things related to Lucretia, and also mentioned Tyrian and his “Sea Mist” a few times.

However, she clearly did not know as much about Tyrian and the Sea Mist as she did about Lucretia.

“Tyrian Abnomar once served the Frostholm queen. That was half a century ago, not so far from now. Some older Humans have also heard about this,” the shopkeeper said casually. “But they’ve only heard about it. The city-states in the Frost Sea region were rather closed off decades ago and had limited dealings with Pland…”

Duncan felt his heart pounding. Of course he knew who the Frostholm queen was. There was even a life-sized Frostholm Queen Doll in his home that bounced around all day. But he had never thought that the queen who had been executed by rebels half a century ago would form another kind of connection with him like this – through a “firstborn son” whose existence he himself had only just learned about.

“The Frostholm rebellion half a century ago…” He chose his words carefully, trying his best to act like a normal guest who just liked gossip. “I’ve seen it in history books, but the writing is very vague…”

“That matter was vague to begin with,” the shopkeeper waved a hand. “They say it was tied to ‘that ship’. Who would dare record it clearly?”

“Tyrian Abnomar took his men and became a pirate after the Frostholm rebellion?” Duncan asked again. “Is he still active in the Frost Sea now?”

“Seems so,” the shopkeeper recalled. “Anyway, that’s what a fellow Elf who did business at sea told me more than twenty years ago.”

“Then… do Tyrian and Lucretia still stay in touch?”

“How would I know?” The shopkeeper waved her hand. “I’m just an ordinary old madam who runs a shop on a street in Pland. At most, I saw them once in my early years and just happen to remember a bit more than you Humans do. How could I know everything?”

“Well… that’s true.”

Duncan smacked his lips and realized he seemed a bit too concerned about this matter, so he wisely did not keep asking.

But the old woman across from him suddenly seemed to remember something. She stood up from behind the counter. “Ah, right. Speaking of Lucretia, I suddenly remembered something. It’s been kept here with me for many years. I wonder if you, Guest, would be interested?”

As she spoke, the shopkeeper walked to a low door in the corner by the stairs. She opened it and rummaged around in the storage room inside. After fussing around for quite a while, she finally took a box more than half a meter long from the very back of the storage room and set it on the counter.

“This is…” Duncan looked in confusion at the thing she had taken out.

“A Doll,” the old woman said with a kindly smile, carefully lifting the lid. “Her name is Nilu – do you remember what I just mentioned? Many years ago, Lucretia and her brother bought a Doll from my shop. But that Doll was actually one of a pair of sisters. The one she took away was a sister named ‘Lunie’. The one left here is named ‘Nilu’.”

Chapter 162: Nilu

Duncan quietly fixed his gaze on Nilu, the doll lying in the box.

It was just an ordinary jointed doll. Her look matched the “court maiden” style that had been popular in the city-states a century ago. She had beautiful curly golden hair and a dress trimmed all over with lace. The joints in her arms used an old-fashioned ball-joint structure, even more obvious than Alice’s. Her face was made of porcelain, and around her mouth and eyes were the telltale seams that marked an old-style doll.

To be fair, this doll was made with great care and had been kept in very good condition. It was hard to believe she had already been lying in this box for a full century. She was far from Alice, that “doll” who was almost no different from a real person, but this little one named Nilu could still be called pretty.

A hundred years ago, Lucretia had bought from this shop the other doll that formed a pair with this little one, a doll called Lunie. Now the one that had been left behind back then, Nilu, lay quietly in the box in front of Duncan.

And Duncan himself had only wandered into this shop on a whim today. His first goal had only been to mess with… to buy a wig for Alice, and to ask a bit about how to maintain and care for dolls.

Fate really was a strange thing.

“This doesn’t look like something that’s been kept for a whole century,” Duncan said thoughtfully. “She only looks a little old.”

The shopkeeper said slowly: “Things made by elves are always famous for being long-lasting. We usually have to use them for a very, very long time. My skill at making dolls is nothing grand enough to call myself a master, but it should still be far above many of my peers. I would never want a child I crafted so carefully to fail at keeping someone company for at least one or two centuries.”

“…I understand, but for humans this is already an antique,” Duncan raised an eyebrow. He quickly pulled himself out of his thoughts and realized this well-preserved doll was not some simple item. “I don’t think I can afford her.”

He had not forgotten that a single century-old dagger had already earned him more than a year of an ordinary person’s living expenses from old Mr. Morris. This finely crafted, well-kept doll in front of him… there was no way she would be cheap.

“An antique? I never thought of it that way,” the shopkeeper chuckled, her plump face full of good cheer. “She’s not expensive. In fact, if you buy that wig and the matching silver hair ornament, I can sell this doll to you at cost – the original cost from back then, 142 sola.”

This time Duncan was the one who was surprised: “Why?”

“Maybe it’s just that you and she are meant to meet,” the shopkeeper said slowly. “Nilu has been lying here quietly for many years, and not a single fated master has come to take her away. This ‘younger sister’ who was left behind all alone is actually very lonely. Today I almost had no guests at all, yet you, a gentleman who truly loves dolls, came and chatted with me for so long. You even happened to mention Lucretia, the young miss who took Lunie away a hundred years ago. I feel there might be some guidance from fate here…”

“Fate…” Duncan’s mouth twitched. He usually liked using that word to fool other people, yet he had not expected to have it used on him. Then he understood, and the look he gave the elven old woman turned odd: “So the real situation is that she won’t sell, right?”

“…It is fate.”

“Because she has a bit of a link to that ‘Abnormal’ family that was under The curse, so she simply won’t sell at all, right?”

“…It really is fate.”

“Does this doll have any other traits like The curse? Like coming back on her own after someone throws her away? Or going into the kitchen while people sleep to look for a knife…”

The old woman finally opened her eyes wide, and her voice jumped by an octave: “I even hired a priest to drive out the evil! I still have the exorcism certificate…”

Duncan chuckled: “See? So it really is because people suspect this doll is carrying The curse and so she won’t sell, right?”

The old woman said nothing.

“I run an antique shop in the Lower City,” Duncan sighed. “An antique shop in the Lower City. You know what that means.”

“…I really don’t like dealing with business folk, especially ones like you,” the old woman shook her head with a sigh. “All right, yes, that is the real reason. Nilu stayed unsold for a long, long time, and the longer she sat there, the older she looked, so I simply pushed her into storage. If you really want her, then take her at a discount for 75 sola. At least let me earn back what I spent on the priest for the exorcism…”

“Deal.” Duncan agreed before she could even finish.

Either way, he really had grown very interested in this doll. Even though there was no proof at all that this little one had any connection with Lucretia, just the factor of “fate” was enough for him to decide to buy her.

This was his instinctive reaction after suddenly learning that “he” had somehow produced a pair of children. Who knew when those siblings might show up, and who knew what trouble they would bring. Now that he had found something related to Lucretia, whether it would be useful or not, he wanted to keep it by his side first and study it slowly.

In a world that held supernatural powers and all kinds of strange things, objects that carried a “connection” like this often played a role in occult studies.

“Then I’ll leave Nilu in your care,” the shopkeeper said. Duncan’s quick answer clearly stunned the old madam, and she looked as if she already regretted not asking for a higher price. But she soon shook her head and pushed the box with the doll toward him. Before Duncan could reach out, she could not help speaking again: “You must take good care of this child. I can see you truly love dolls, sir, but I still have to remind you: don’t treat Nilu as some cheap piece of merchandise.”

“Of course,” Duncan said as he took the wooden box and closed the lid. Then he glanced at the wig and hair ornament he had picked out earlier. “How much are these two together?”

“425 sola. Fixed price.”

Duncan’s face instantly twisted as if his teeth hurt.

In the Lower City, that was two months of living expenses for a whole family. But in the Upper City… it was only enough to buy two “accessories” for some rich person’s luxury goods.

He even wavered for a moment, wondering if he should just give up on them, but he soon pushed that thought away.

This was the gift he had promised Alice (even if Alice's mood might be a little strange when she received it). On the other hand, thinking of what he had gained in this doll shop today, this price did not seem completely unacceptable.

After comforting himself that way, Duncan let out a quiet breath and got ready to pay up without arguing.

Only when he was paying did he suddenly remember something, so he could not help asking one more question: "Right, back then, why did Lucretia only buy Lunie and not take Nilu, the younger sister?"

"…Do you really want to know?" The shopkeeper looked at him with a slightly mysterious air. "This matter… is another secret related to the Abnormal family."

Duncan instinctively leaned in closer: "Now I'm even more curious."

"Then you should settle the bill first."

Duncan froze for a moment, then paid with a helpless smile: "Can you tell me now?"

"Oh, it's actually nothing much," the old madam said offhand while taking the money. "Those two children simply didn't bring enough money back then. Lucretia left with tears in her eyes and said that when she had money in the future, she would definitely come back for Nilu as well. But looking at things now, she must have forgotten."

Duncan: "…"

He could not tell if it was this old madam's way of talking that was strange, or if all the elves in this world had a few screws loose.

…

On the gently rocking Vanished, rising and falling with the sea, Alice carried the last batch of supplies into the cabins and then came back up to the upper deck. At once she saw the captain standing quietly by the rail, as if he was lost in thought.

“Captain~~” The doll girl trotted over happily. “I’ve taken everything down to the cabins! The food and cookware went to the galley, and the rest went to the captain’s cabin!”

“Mm.” Duncan came back to himself and let out a soft breath. His gaze finally settled on Alice. “Good work.”

“Captain… are you feeling better now?” Alice looked Duncan up and down and asked, a bit unsure. “Your face suddenly looked really strange just now. Are you really all right?”

Duncan shook his head: “Don’t worry. It’s a small problem.”

He still felt a little unsettled. His head was full of the two names that had suddenly appeared, Tyrian and Lucretia, and the trouble they might bring. When he looked at Alice, this cursed Doll who absolutely had some link to the Frostholm Queen, his thoughts grew even harder to settle. In the end, though, he pushed many of those words back down.

No matter what link she had or didn’t have to the Frostholm Queen, Alice was just a doll who knew nothing. Talking to her about some things… it would be better to go talk to Shirley, that illiterate girl.

At least Shirley had a somewhat educated dog at her side.

He turned his head to look at the pigeon resting on the deck. Its outline flickered in the air, and then it vanished from above the deck in a burst of flame.

Alice watched the spot where the flame disappeared, wide-eyed: “Did AI go to ‘move cargo’ again?”

“Mm. There isn’t much this time,” Duncan nodded lightly. Then he looked at Alice and let a slight smile show. “It’s a gift for you.”

Alice’s eyes lit up: “A gift? A gift really for me?! Captain, you really—”

The doll girl had not finished the second half of her sentence when a whirl of ghostly green flame suddenly appeared over the deck beside them. In the blink of an eye AI finished her teleportation from the city-state of Pland to the Vanished, and as the flames rose, a new batch of supplies appeared before Alice’s eyes.

That doll could not finish the rest of her words at all.

The first thing that appeared before her eyes was a wig…

Chapter 163: An Exhausting Conversation

The skeletal pigeon, wrapped in spirit form flame, circled twice above the deck. The cargo from the city-state of Pland appeared in the fire. Alice stared blankly at the first thing that showed up in front of her, and only after a long moment did she lift her head to look at the captain.

To be honest, in that moment Duncan almost thought this doll was going to burst into tears and run off. That had been the most likely reaction in the long list he had imagined from Alice. Instead, he and this silly doll just stared at each other for a long time, big eyes to big eyes, until she finally gave a dazed little nod and said: “Thank you!”

Duncan: “…?”

“You really bought me new hair!” The next second Alice’s face broke into a wide, joyful smile, as if she had just received the most wonderful gift. “I thought you were just joking last time! Mr. Goathead said that wigs for dolls are very expensive things…”

Duncan: “…”

The reaction he had waited so long for did not happen. His persecution plan had run into a huge failure from the very start. The one who was supposed to be persecuted was overjoyed and even full of heartfelt gratitude.

He felt like a prankster who had suddenly lost his own fun.

“Captain? Captain, why are you spacing out again?” Alice’s voice suddenly sounded, pulling Duncan out of his daze. The doll was holding the wig in her hands, standing on tiptoe with her face almost pressed to Duncan’s nose. “You spaced out so many times today…”

Duncan blinked and leaned his face back a little, staring at the cursed Doll with a strange look: “I didn’t think you had such a big heart. Last time, when I talked about wigs, you were really depressed. I thought that when you got this gift, you’d at least have a bit of an inner struggle…”

“I was depressed about losing hair. Why would I be depressed about getting new hair?” Alice blinked, as if she thought Duncan’s whole view of the world was wrong, and explained: “I’m a doll!”

Duncan finally understood where the problem lay.

Alice was usually so lively on the ship that, aside from the strange bones in her neck, she looked just like an ordinary person. After spending so long with her, he had unconsciously started treating her like a human, and had forgotten how different her values were as a doll…

As a doll, why would she care about wearing a wig? Do humans care that much when they put on a new pair of shoes?

“Forget it, I was just thinking too much,” Duncan said, covering his face and waving a hand. As the greatest calamity on the Boundless Sea, he once again felt unable to keep up his image in front of Alice. “Anyway… as long as you like it.”

“I like it!” Alice said happily, hugging the wig. Then she craned her neck over Duncan’s shoulder to look at the rest of the things on the deck. “And the rest of this…”

“This is also for you,” Duncan sighed, trying his best to ignore the visual shock of an elegant, beautiful gothic doll hugging a wig with such joy. He

turned and picked up a box from the deck. “Open it and take a look.”

Alice opened the delicate little wooden box curiously and saw a silver hair ornament made of diamond-shaped pieces linked together, lying quietly on the velvet lining.

She looked up in shock and saw the captain nodding slightly to her.

“Last time I took away the feather hair clip you found in the cabin,” Duncan said calmly. “Back then I promised to buy you a new one. I’m keeping that promise now.”

Alice froze for a long moment before she finally reacted. Her smile held a joy she had never shown before: “Thank you, Captain! Captain, you’re the best!”

“Don’t be so loud,” Duncan said, ears ringing from the doll’s sudden high-pitched voice. He could not help waving his hand. “It’s just a hair ornament. No need to get so excited.”

“It’s not just the ornament, there’s also the new hair you bought me!”

Duncan suddenly felt a little embarrassed. A strong sense of shame, the kind you get when you set up a prank and the target thanks you earnestly instead, wrapped around his heart: “…Don’t bring up that wig.”

Alice, however, did not notice the captain’s subtle mood at all. The doll with not many thoughts in her head was fully immersed in her joy, and soon her gaze naturally fell on the last wooden box on the deck.

It was a wooden box a little more than half a meter long – or rather, a wooden trunk – with elegant, old-fashioned decorations and brass locks and hinges that gave it a sense of quality at a glance.

For some reason, it also reminded her of her own “house.”

“What is this?” Alice put down the wig and hair ornament beside her, walked over, and pushed the trunk curiously. Then she looked up and asked.

“It’s also from the doll shop, but this one isn’t for you,” Duncan said casually. “You can open it and take a look.”

Alice made a soft sound of acknowledgment and opened the trunk curiously.

A finely made doll in a classical maiden style lay quietly inside the trunk.

Alice: “…?”

“You can call her Nilu,” Duncan’s voice came from beside her. “But unlike you, she’s just an ordinary doll… probably.”

Alice did not react for a long time. After nearly ten seconds, she finally moved. With a light click-pop, her head dropped straight into Nilu’s box and rolled together with the small doll inside…

“He… he… help me…”

Duncan sighed, picked up Alice’s head with practiced ease, and put it back in place. He looked at this embarrassing fellow helplessly: “Did you really need to react like that?”

Alice only held her head with both hands and twisted her neck back into place. Then she widened her eyes at her captain, her face full of disbelief: “Captain, you… you’ve got yourself a new doll…”

“What nonsense!” Duncan felt that something was very wrong the moment he heard that and quickly cut her off before Alice could spew more rubbish. “Didn’t I just say that Nilu is not like you? She won’t run and jump around the place. And what do you mean I ‘got myself a new doll’? That makes it sound like I have some kind of strange collecting hobby.”

“But if you bought a doll and brought her back, isn’t that…”

“There is a very special reason behind this,” Duncan said softly, letting out a breath as he stood and looked out over the distant sea. He tried to use the serious, deep look on his face to suppress the rubbish running around in Alice’s silly head. “This doll named Nilu and another doll named Lunie were originally a pair. Many years ago, my daughter took Lunie away. By coincidence, I found Nilu again today, left behind and gathering dust in the shop. I thought… I should buy her.”

Duncan did not hide the information he had just learned. He said it in a natural tone. No matter what, he now had to play the role of “Captain Duncan” well, and from that persona, he had to “of course know” about his own pair of children.

Alice, unsurprisingly, stared wide-eyed at her captain, her face full of shock.

“C-captain, you have a daughter?!” The doll held her head with both hands, as if afraid that in the next second it would leave home again from sheer shock. “I… this is the first time I’ve ever heard that!”

Duncan sighed in his heart. He was thinking that this was also the first time he had heard of it himself…

But his face stayed as calm as ever. He only gave a small nod: “Is that so strange? I also have a son, and I haven’t seen either of them for a century.”

“You also have a son?!” Alice was even more stunned. She even took two steps back. Then her eyes spun twice as her brain worked in some way, and she suddenly blurted out: “Then doesn’t that mean they also have a mom?”

Duncan: “…”

In that moment, he and Alice just stared at each other, big eyes against big eyes.

“I’m starting to regret opening this topic with you,” Duncan finally sighed after a long time, his face full of weary age. “I don’t want to talk about this.”

“Oh… oh, okay!” Alice had no idea what she had just imagined in her head. After a short pause she nodded again and again. Then she looked down at Nilu in the wooden trunk and suddenly understood: “Ah, then that feather-shaped hair clip I found in the cabin last time… was that your daughter’s?”

Duncan gave no clear answer.

He himself was not sure either. But thinking of the deep, involuntary feeling of nostalgia that had risen from his heart when he saw that hair clip, Alice’s guess was probably not far off.

Then he noticed that Alice had been sneaking looks at him the whole time. He noticed the strange look on the doll’s face, as if she wanted to say something but kept stopping.

“If you have something to say, just say it,” he said lightly. “Staring at me in secret like that is ruder than speaking without a filter.”

“Ah, it’s nothing, nothing, I just…” Alice waved her hands, then finally said hesitantly: “I just suddenly feel… that you still have some humanity.”

Duncan: “…Is that supposed to be a compliment?”

Alice froze at once. Then, as if she remembered something Mr. Goathead had taught her, she showed a guilty look: “Ah, sorry, Captain. I shouldn’t insult you by saying you have humanity…”

“I… thank you,” Duncan sighed, waving a hand, his face showing how tired he was in both body and soul. “Take your gifts and go back. I want some time alone.”

“Oh.”

Chapter 164: No One Answered the Call

Alice left in a good mood. It even looked like she could stay happy for many days. Duncan stayed alone on the deck, looking at the wooden box that held “Nilu”.

He controlled the “avatar” located in the city-state of Pland and left the Upper City. He was now riding a bicycle back to the antique shop. Before leaving that doll shop, he had talked with the old madam shopkeeper about many things related to Lucretia and Tyrian, but he did not gain anything more.

As the shopkeeper herself had said, she was only an ordinary citizen, just one whose life lasted longer than that of humans and who had personally seen some events many years ago. Aside from a brief meeting back then and some hearsay, she actually did not know much about those two “descendants of Duncan”.

On the Vanished, Duncan was lost in thought.

To his surprise, this body even had a pair of children, and they were still alive. From the sound of it, that pair of siblings were not ordinary people. One had once sworn loyalty to the queen of Frostholm and had now become the greatest pirate lord of the Frost Sea. The other had long drifted along the border of the civilized world, doing all kinds of mysterious explorations, and was respectfully called the “witch of the sea” by captains.

Such a pair of “children” only made Duncan feel troubled, and a little nervous.

Right now he was “Captain Duncan” of the Vanished, and it seemed he would have to remain “Captain Duncan” for the foreseeable future. So he had to find a way to maintain this identity. But if one day in the future… he really met that pair of siblings, what should he do?

Should he act like a kind father with dutiful children? Or should he act cold and ruthless? Should he greet them, or should he walk past them with an icy nod?

According to the shopkeeper, a hundred years ago Tyrian and his sibling had a “falling-out” with their father. After some mysterious “family dispute”, the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star parted ways with their flagship, the Vanished. That was all the world knew.

But what exactly had happened back then, probably only those three people knew.

Duncan let out a soft sigh.

Whatever the truth back then, one thing seemed certain: his relationship with that pair of siblings could not be the warm, filial bond between father and child. If they really met, it would be safer to lean harder toward the “unfortunate family” side of things…

He bent down and picked up the wooden box that held “Nilu”. On the velvet lining inside, the doll maiden, only a few dozen centimeters tall, lay quietly. This little thing, born a hundred years ago, was now a new “member” of the Vanished.

“Was ‘she’ really connected to Lucretia? Or did Lucretia still keep, by her side, the doll named ‘Lunie’ that she had bought a hundred years ago?”

Duncan had not thought much when he bought Nilu. But now his thoughts began to stir. Holding the wooden box, he returned to the captain's cabin.

Goathead was at the wheel like always. As soon as Duncan opened the door, Goathead's noisy voice rang out at once: "Ah! The great captain has returned to his loyal captain's cabin. It seems you brought many supplies from the city-state. Your loyal—etcetera—cares very much about the food on board. If you do not mind, I shall personally guide Miss Alice to become a proper…"

"Shut up. Stop messing around with that doll over the recipes. I don't want my next meal to look like a pot of Abyssal demons' vomit." Duncan glared at Goathead. "Where are we now, and how far are we from Pland?"

"Oh, we are still heading for Pland at full speed, and we have already made several successful Spirit Realm boosts on the way—like skipping stones along the edge of the Mortal Realm. Now the Vanished is only ten days away from that city-state," Goathead said at once, sounding pleased. "I guess before long, you will feel a clear rush of strength when you walk in the Spirit Realm. The Vanished's influence will become your greatest help when you move around inside the city-state…"

Duncan looked quietly at Goathead. Goathead stopped his babbling, stayed silent for two seconds, then suddenly added: "A loyal First Mate always understands his captain best."

"Good." Duncan nodded and walked toward his cabin with the box in his hands. Soon he stopped again. Words turned quickly in his mind, and at last, with a calm face, he asked in a casual tone: "Tell me, if Tyrian and Lucretia saw me again, how would they react?"

This was a test he had chosen after careful thought. It was the most normal-sounding question he could come up with, one that would not arouse suspicion yet could still give him some information.

He did not ask Goathead what he thought of those siblings, because that kind of question would sound too stiff. He also did not ask about what had happened between those siblings and the Vanished in the past, because that would expose his own situation. The question he finally chose fit his identity better and matched the way he and Goathead usually talked.

Goathead clearly froze for a moment. His voice stayed hesitant for a long time before it reached Duncan's ears: "You mean… your children… Sorry, Captain, I do not know if I should speak about your family matters, since you rarely mention them to me. But if I have to say it, if I have to say…"

The usually quick-tongued Goathead stammered several times before he finally went on: "If I have to say it, I think we might have another fight with Tyrian, just like back in Frostholm. After all, he always likes to solve problems with cannons. As for Miss Lucretia… she would probably stay far away…"

Duncan neither agreed nor disagreed, but suddenly he realized two things.

First, he remembered that Goathead had once mentioned that the Vanished had "fought a battle" near the city-state of Frostholm. That battle had actually been with Tyrian!

Second, Goathead's first reaction was strange, and he had even stressed that Duncan rarely talked to him about those siblings. From that line, did it mean this Goathead had never actually spent time with those siblings? Did he only know about them from what Duncan had "told" him?

Hadn't this guy been on the Vanished from the very beginning?!

Duncan's gaze narrowed a little, but nothing showed on his face. He only nodded to show he had heard Goathead's answer, then calmly kept walking and went back to his cabin.

The heavy oak door closed behind him, blocking Goathead's view from the room with the enchanted sea chart and letting Duncan's mood slowly calm down.

He let out a long breath, took "Nilu" out of the wooden box, and placed her on his desk. He stared at the doll for several minutes, then greeted her: "Hello, my name is Duncan."

The doll, of course, did not respond.

She really was just a doll.

Duncan suddenly felt a bit foolish. He gave an awkward smile and thought to himself: [Good thing no one on this ship has the guts to peek into the captain's cabin.] Then he opened the drawer at his side and took out an item.

It was a small, delicate hair clip shaped like waves and feathers.

This was an "old item" that Alice had dug out from the ship's cabin.

Duncan quietly let his gaze rest on the little hair clip. As before, that strange feeling of nostalgia slowly spread from deep inside him.

It felt like the only strand of "humanity" left by the original master of this body, a faint fragment of emotion that still remained in his heart.

"This really is probably Lucretia's…" Duncan murmured to himself. "Was it a gift he never managed to give her, or the only keepsake she left on this ship after she left…"

He slowly picked up the hair clip and turned it gently under the sunlight. The sunlight came through the window and made the silver edge of the hair clip shine.

A small cluster of green flames spread from Duncan's fingertips and, in the blink of an eye, engulfed the hair clip. Then the flames flowed through the

air and wrapped around the doll Nilu.

Duncan calmed his mind and tried to feel whether there was any supernatural power left inside these two objects, or even the slightest “connection” that pointed toward some far-off place.

However, the flames soon faded. The doll and the hair clip showed no reaction.

Was it because they really were ordinary mortal objects? Or was it because Lucretia was now at the border of the civilized world, so far away that whatever “connection” remained in these two things had grown too weak for even the fire of the spirit form to catch?

Duncan frowned and let the flames spread out again. At the same time, with a feeling he could not even explain to himself, he tried calling out: “Lucretia… Lucy?”

He used the nickname for the name Lucretia—maybe the bond built by that nickname would be a little stronger than the formal name?

Nothing happened.

Duncan waited for a long time and, in the end, could only put out the flames in disappointment.

At the same time, in a distant border region at the eternal edge of The Veil, the clockwork doll “Lunie” suddenly stopped while she was wiping a table.

Inside this Engineering Construct that Lucretia had personally modified countless times, and that now almost counted as an Alchemical Lifeform, there came a sharp howl of gears and bearings spinning wildly, followed by a series of grating creaks.

With a click, the clockwork key on Lunie’s back popped out and fell to the floor. Her alloy-reinforced arms drooped stiffly, and a wisp of pale smoke

slowly rose from the gap in the back of her maid shell…

Chapter 165: Lucretia’s Pressure

Along with a string of strange noises, the clockwork doll froze up completely like a rusted machine. Almost at the same time, Lucretia, who was in a nearby cabin, sensed the anomaly in her creation.

The cabin door was pushed open. A stack of flying colored paper sheets whirled into the room like a cyclone and, as they spun, gathered into a human shape. Lucretia, the “witch of the sea”, stepped out from the colored paper and, at first glance, saw Lunie, who had slipped down to sit by the table with her head hanging.

“Lunie?” Lucretia hurried forward and at once noticed the clockwork key lying on the floor nearby. She picked up the key and then moved closer, patting the mechanism box on the clockwork doll’s back. “What happened?”

A series of broken creaks came from inside Lunie. After a while, some of her parts finally began to move again, and a badly distorted voice sounded from her chest: “Old Master… is looking for you…”

With a clang, the clockwork key in Lucretia’s hand fell to the floor.

Lunie turned her head toward the sound and, by instinct, reached out to grope for her own clockwork key, trying to put it back into her back. But halfway through the motion she jammed again, and the sound of gears spinning idly followed.

Lucretia’s face changed sharply. When she heard the words “Old Master”, her pupils trembled. But the sounds of failure inside Lunie soon snapped

her back to herself. She shook her head hard, forced down her swirling thoughts, and grabbed the clockwork doll's shoulders: "Lunie, stand by."

The clockwork doll slowly closed her eyes. "Command received, Lunie entering standby."

A short time later, deep in the Radiant Star's hull, in a brightly lit cabin, Lucretia was busy beside a workbench.

This was a laboratory that could be called "complete and advanced" even by the standards of the Truth Academy's headquarters. The wide room was filled with intricate machines and pneumatic tube lines that supplied power to various devices. Between the countless machines stood auxiliary devices covered in magic runes, along with many crystal containers or reactor boilers that gave off a faint light. A dozen automated mechanism dolls tended these self-running devices, so Lucretia could focus all her attention on the work in front of her.

In front of this "witch of the sea", Lunie lay quietly on the wide workbench.

The clockwork doll had already been taken apart. The outer shell shaped like a maid's outfit had been set aside. The fine-gold frame and all sorts of brass mechanism parts almost covered the whole bench. Only the part of Lunie's body above the chest still remained intact. That part lay at the edge of the platform. She stared blankly at her disassembled body and blinked her eyes from time to time.

"Is it… easy… to fix?" A slightly off-key voice came from Lunie's chest.

"Don't worry. The drive mechanisms just jammed all of a sudden and warped the bearings," Lucretia said as she worked without looking up. "The workload is large, but the repair itself is not complicated. Your 'heart' was not damaged."

Lunie slowly moved her eyes and saw the “heart” placed at the center of the workbench.

It was a delicate clockwork heart sphere made from countless complex metal plates joined together. It floated quietly above a pile of parts. The metal plates on its surface shifted from time to time, revealing the structure inside. When the plates turned to the right angle, one could clearly see that the inside of the sphere was covered in shining runes, and something even more slender floated at the center of those runes.

It was a piece of a finger—a very slim, very fragile finger, even thinner than the finger of a human child. A dollmaker had carefully crafted it a hundred years ago.

That was the true core and true essence of the mechanism doll “Lunie”—the last proof left in this world of a certain doll that had been created a hundred years ago.

Lucretia noticed Lunie’s gaze. She looked up at it, and her hands suddenly paused.

After a moment, she went back to work and spoke as if by accident: “I turned you into what you are now. Have you ever hated me for it?”

“Lunie… why would Lunie hate you?” The doll’s head on the workbench spoke in a stiff voice. “Mistress… gave Lunie life. Lunie is… glad because of that…”

“But at first, all of this was only because I was acting on a whim. For that whim, I destroyed your original body,” Lucretia said softly. “For a long time at the beginning, I did not realize that the border’s influence had given you real thinking. Back then, I only thought you were a machine and carried out many ‘experimental modifications’ on you without caring about the consequences.”

Lunie did not answer her Mistress. After a short silence, she suddenly spoke: “You are tense. You have something on your mind—under normal conditions, Mistress would not suddenly say such strange things.”

Lucretia stayed silent for two or three seconds. “…Do you remember what you just said? When I arrived at the dining room and woke you up.”

“…Memory search failed. Lunie does not remember.”

“You told me that ‘Old Master’ was looking for me.”

A strange sound came from the clockwork doll’s chest, not from a fault, but from confused thinking.

“Do you really not remember?” Lucretia raised her head and gazed quietly into Lunie’s eyes.

“Memory search failed. Lunie does not remember.”

“…Then it seems my terrifying father does not want me to have any chance to look back at his situation,” Lucretia said, a complicated smile appearing on her face. She slowly took out a warped set of gears, and her tone drifted. “He only sent a one-way signal to tell me… he knows where the Radiant Star is. He knows how to find me…”

“You are afraid.”

“Scared to death—but more than fear, it is a kind of… sadness.”

“Sad? Why?”

Lucretia looked into Lunie’s eyes. After a long time, she gently shook her head. “That feeling is too complex for you. You probably cannot understand it yet.”

“All right. Lunie will try to understand later,” the clockwork doll replied. Then she asked, “Do you think Old Master is giving you some kind of

warning?”

“…I do not know, but it really does feel like a warning,” Lucretia said softly. “It even feels like a kind of declaration before a hunt… He has returned from Subspace, and he is even harder to grasp than the last time he came back. Maybe I should warn my Big Brother…”

“You really should remind Mr. Tyrian. He has already set out for Pland, and the governor of Pland said that the Vanished is approaching that city-state.”

Lucretia nodded lightly and said nothing more. She just lowered her head and went on working.

…

Duncan carefully put “Nilu” back into the antique wooden chest, then returned the feather-shaped hair clip to the drawer.

Then he stared at the box holding “Nilu” and felt troubled.

As a grown man, he felt that keeping a maiden-style doll in his bedroom was a bit wrong.

But aside from keeping it in his bedroom, he could not think of a better place.

Even though the first test had gained nothing and he had not found any hint of the supernatural in the doll “Nilu”, this was still an item related to “Lucretia”. Since he could not be sure whether it would be useful in the future, he did not dare leave the doll anywhere out of his sight.

After struggling with it for a while, Duncan sighed and set Nilu’s box for now at the head of his bed.

“If you really have something special, then show it soon,” he said as he looked at the ornate old box and shook his head. “Don’t be like Alice, who

had to be thrown into the sea before she showed off that coffin-charging-through-the-waves stunt.”

The wooden box, of course, did not respond, but Duncan did not care.

He went to the window and looked at the sky outside.

The veil of night had already descended. The pale, dim glow of the World’s Wound shone over the Boundless Sea.

The great banishing power brought by the Sun had faded from the Mortal Realm. Twisted, ominous, corrupting forces were slowly rising all over the world. At this time of night, humans would enter Dreamwalking in order to avoid the world’s interference with their sanity.

But for Duncan… he had never felt any discomfort under the veil of night, nor had he seen the Shadows that frightened ordinary people.

Night was when his mind was sharpest.

He went back to his desk, quietly laid out a sheet of blank paper, and picked up a fountain pen.

He had just bought these things from the city-state of Pland.

After thinking for a moment, he wrote line after line on the paper:

In 1889, a fragment of the Sun appeared and caused the great fire of Pland;

Under the Veil of the factories in the Sixth District, a “Mortal Realm” burned by the fire was hidden;

Inside the Cathedral in the Sixth District community there existed a warped space-time that seemed to be a closed time loop. Two completely opposite Mortal Realms overlapped inside the Cathedral;

Dog’s “humanity” had an unknown source, but it was clearly not the power of the Sun fragment;

The statue of the Goddess inside the Cathedral in the Sixth District seemed to have been affected by a Subspace rift. The nun in the underground sanctum seemed to have died while fighting against the Subspace invasion…

Chapter 166: The Captain Awaits You in Dreamwalking

Over this period of time, Duncan wrote down all the known information one by one on paper. He then drew lines between them according to how they were connected. Among these clues, he threaded in Nina and Shirley's memories of the great fire, as well as their own "dreams" that had clearly already become distorted.

After he finished listing all the clues, Duncan started a new line at the bottom of the chart. He frowned, fell into thought, and while thinking, he wrote down a few sentences—

First, in this world, everything could undergo "corruption"—everything except Subspace.

Second, the Mortal Realm of this world was built on unstable foundations. Space was unstable, time was unstable, and even the Mortal Realm itself was not necessarily as unshakable as people perceived.

Third, the power of Subspace had already invaded Pland. The Visions inside that small Cathedral in the Sixth District were proof of it. The shard of the Sun from eleven years ago might not have been the key part of the whole affair at all. In terms of "rank"… it was far more likely that Subspace itself had brought about Pland's current Anomaly.

Duncan put down his fountain pen and looked at the three lines he had written. They were not clues, but "premises" and "conclusions" that had a great deal to do with Pland's current state.

His gaze fell on the first line. It was the shortest, yet it was the foundation of everything. The “inspiration” for it came from an offhand remark he had overheard when he went to open an account at the city-state bank.

Thoughtful, he picked up the pen again and drew a line from that item to one of the clues above—the Cathedral in the Sixth District that was in a Space-Time Lock.

The corruption had started from the Cathedral. It showed itself as disordered time and space and an overlay of different “world-lines”. The level of corruption was very high. By the look of it, even the Storm Goddess’s monitoring of the Mortal Realm had been affected… So how exactly was this kind of corruption being carried out? Was what had been corrupted… really only the Cathedral itself?

He recalled what he had said when he parted ways with Shirley—that this matter ought to be made bigger, but an ordinary citizen’s report was not quite enough.

As he thought, a faint smile appeared on Duncan’s face. He turned his head and looked at the pigeon pacing back and forth on the windowsill.

The pigeon stopped at once and stared straight at Duncan: “There’s murderous intent!”

Duncan ignored it completely and snapped his fingers.

A tuft of ghostly green flame burst out of the spirit compass in AI’s chest. The spirit compass opened, and its needle began to spin. The boundary between the Mortal Realm and illusion blurred in an instant. Duncan’s vision swayed, and he stepped into the state of walking in the Spirit Realm. That familiar dark, chaotic space and the countless starlights filling it appeared before his eyes.

He stood still in the depths of the darkness and took a gentle breath to steady himself. Then he followed a faint sense and drew near a point of starlight not far away.

He came to the starlight. Without actually touching it, he could clearly sense the mind of that young Inquisitor. On the other side of this starlight was Vanna's spirit.

Compared to the first time he had found this point of starlight, Duncan could clearly feel that the connection between him and Vanna had grown much stronger. Her last visit to the antique shop with Heidi had strengthened the link between them, and that strengthened connection could now be put to use.

Duncan turned his head and looked into the darkness beside him. AI, in spirit form, was circling in midair in boredom. When the bird noticed its Master's gaze, it flew over at once: "Who is calling the fleet?"

"Remember how we connected to Shirley's mind last time?"

AI thought for a moment and tilted its head: "You have to pay extra!"

"This time it will indeed be a bit harder. The other party is a devout Saint, so her will should be much firmer than Shirley's, and it might even draw the Storm Goddess's attention," Duncan said with a slight nod. But he still slowly stretched out his finger, inching toward that cluster of starlight. "Still, the connection between Vanna and me has already been strengthened. If we only make a shallow contact and do no damage, it shouldn't be a big problem.

"After all, this is just a righteous complaint from a concerned captain."

The next second, his fingertip touched the starlight.

Waves of illusory surf seemed to come from some boundless distance, then vanished in an instant. Before Duncan even had time to notice the sound of

the sea, he felt himself make contact with a mind.

…

Vanna rubbed her eyes and lowered her head. She saw that she was holding a thick file in her hands. She looked up again and saw that she was sitting in her room. Her dressing table was in front of her, and in the mirror of the table, her slightly tired face was reflected.

A brief daze rose from deep inside her, but she quickly shook her head and remembered what she had been doing.

She had been continuing her investigation into records of Heretic worship in the city-state of Pland before 1889. After leaving the archives, she had borrowed a portion of the documents she had not yet had time to study in detail from the old priest serving as the Warden there and brought the files home.

At the archives, she and that old priest had discovered an abnormal gap in the records for 1885, but in the end they had not found the files that had vanished. This unusual matter had raised her suspicions. As an Inquisitor who specialized in investigating Heretic cases, she had already decided this would be one of the main focuses of her next round of investigations.

She would assign clerical priests to look up files in several other archives in the city-state. She would have them extract public security reports for the corresponding years from City Hall. She would send Guardian squads to visit and watch the sites where Heretic worship had taken place that year. She would consult Bishop Valentine to see whether they could receive further instructions from the Goddess…

Vanna already had a rough plan for what came next. Before this series of actions unfolded, she first had to finish compiling all Heretic worship incidents between 1886 and 1889.

She glanced at the sky outside and saw the World’s Wound hanging high in the night. Its pale glow spilled over the whole city-state.

She lowered her head again and saw that she was only halfway through the thick file in her hands. Maybe she had been reading for too long and her eyes were tired. The lines of text looked a little blurry.

Wait, no!

Vanna suddenly snapped to attention. She slammed the file shut and turned to look out the window.

It was midnight now, the time when the World’s Wound had the strongest influence. Reading books at this hour was an extremely dangerous act. Even Stewards who had gone through special training avoided reading any text for that one hour around midnight. Let alone that what she had in front of her right now was a highly dangerous historical file she had borrowed from the archives!

A trained member of the Clergy would not make such a mistake… This was not the Mortal Realm. This was her own dream, a dream that was being influenced!

Vanna’s gaze sharpened. The instant she realized her dream had been invaded, she began to search the surroundings for any trace of Intruders. In the next second, she saw them—

On the dressing table right in front of her, in that oval mirror ringed with patterns, a dark and stern figure stood quietly in the shadows. Illusory green flames quietly burned along the edge of the mirror.

The figure, his expression gloomy and imposing, stood there and fixed a calm gaze on Vanna through the mirror. Only when Vanna looked up did he show a faint smile. A deep voice came from within the mirror: “Good

evening, Vanna. This is our first meeting—but I have watched you for a long time. You may call me…”

“Captain Duncan!” Before the voice in the mirror finished speaking, Vanna reacted. This well-trained Inquisitor sprang backward a full two meters, kicking the stool out of the way as she moved. The moment she landed, she forced her mind into focus, pulled her greatsword out of thin air, and swung it down in a leaping strike!

Duncan: “…?!”

There was a deafening crash. The entire dressing table shattered, and the mirror exploded under the blow into countless pieces flying through the air. Duncan’s image turned into scattered light in front of Vanna’s eyes.

Shards of glass clattered to the floor. Vanna gripped her greatsword tight and swept a fierce gaze around her like a lioness already in battle. At the same time, she began to murmur a benediction and tried to use the mental self-control techniques she had trained in to break free of this corrupted dream and force herself awake.

Yet just as she felt herself about to reach the world of the Mortal Realm, that deep, commanding voice sounded again, echoing in her ears:

“Your reaction surprised me a little.”

Vanna’s eyes flew wide. She looked toward the source of the voice and saw only the broken fragments of the mirror scattered all over the room.

On the surface of every shard, illusory flames began to quietly rise. Inside every shard, a Captain Duncan stood silently in the darkness.

This legendary Great Terror, the moving calamity of the Boundless Sea, looked at the fully alert Vanna with a hint of helplessness in his gaze.

“Relax a little, child. I only want to talk to you about something,” came the voices of a thousand Captain Duncans, shaking Vanna’s resolve. “It concerns Pland…”

“So it’s the mirror…” the young Inquisitor murmured to herself.

Duncan: “Hm?”

Vanna did not answer. Instead, she angled the tip of her greatsword down toward the floor and suddenly smashed her fist into the blade!

There was a thunderous boom. The powerful impact turned into a controlled shockwave that raged through the room. In the next second, every smooth, mirror-like surface in the room turned to dust. Not a single intact reflective surface remained!

The room grew quiet again. Vanna let out a soft breath and slowly straightened up.

She saw Captain Duncan standing quietly in front of her.

No matter how she blinked or shifted her gaze, Captain Duncan remained at the center of her vision, his eyes fixed on hers in a gaze.

“Your guess was not quite accurate. It is not just mirrors, but anything smooth as a mirror,” the ghost captain’s dark, imposing voice sounded directly in her mind. “Right now, I am in your crystalline lenses.”

Chapter 167: A High-Level Report

To be honest, Duncan regretted saying that the moment the words left his mouth—he was genuinely afraid this straightforward Young Lady Vanna would destroy her own eyes on the spot…

The young Inquisitor's reaction had gone far beyond his expectations. He had imagined that a top villain like himself taking the initiative to appear would certainly trigger strong hostility in Vanna, but he had not expected her actions to be so decisive and fast. In almost the blink of an eye she had identified key elements such as Dream Invasion and Mirror Mediums and had carried out targeted countermeasures. This was completely different from when he invaded Shirley's dream before.

From start to finish, she even tried her best to avoid communicating with him, the Intruder. That was an "emergency measure" to keep spiritual corruption from spreading when a dream was invaded.

In fact, the difference between a trained high-ranking Inquisitor and some bastard wild-path supernatural was not small at all. If Duncan's own power had not been so bizarre, and if this entire intrusion had not been built entirely inside Vanna's own mind, then any slightly weaker Intruder would probably have been thrown out after a single exchange with her.

Now Vanna had calmed down. She only quietly watched the ghost captain who had appeared at the center of her vision. She had not acted on the impulse to destroy her own eyes, perhaps because she had realized this dream had already been completely invaded and ordinary expulsion methods were unlikely to work.

She closed her eyes, but Duncan still stood before her in the darkness, his figure becoming even gloomier. His form flickered between real and unreal in the light of the spirit form flame.

“What do you want,” the young Inquisitor finally spoke, her voice as cold and hard as steel. “How did you invade my dream?”

Her attitude was full of hostility. Duncan only found it interesting. The way this Inquisitor acted now was nothing like the polite, calm manner she had shown when she visited the antique shop.

He truly did not know what kind of reaction she would have if she ever learned the truth of the antique shop.

“I only want to tell you one thing,” Duncan skipped the small talk and spoke bluntly. “If you truly care about the safety of the city-state, you should go to the Sixth District and take a look at that small Cathedral.”

After he spoke, he closed his mouth and stood quietly amid the surrounding flames, maintaining a mysterious and imposing presence.

Vanna froze when she heard the ghost captain’s answer.

In that instant, it was as if something pierced a layer of the Veil and lifted a corner that had always been hidden in her mind. “Sixth District, small Cathedral”—these two words carved themselves sharply into her thoughts, leaving her slightly dazed.

But more than that brief daze, the Mortal Realm of her dream being corrupted by Captain Duncan stirred her heart much more strongly. She tried to offer a silent Prayer to the Goddess in her heart. However, the Goddess’s power could not pierce this layer of illusion. She watched the “captain” in front of her with deep wariness, but could not read any emotions from that shadowy figure that she could use to judge him.

After a few seconds, she finally bit down lightly, forced herself to stay calm, and spoke in a low, steady voice: “You invaded an Inquisitor’s dream just for… this?”

“Judge for yourself,” Duncan said calmly. “I look forward to what you will discover there.”

As he said this, he had already begun to feel his connection to this dream quickly become unstable.

A powerful repulsive force was starting to take effect.

He noticed that Vanna had not calmed down as much as she appeared. Though she was speaking with him on the surface, this young Inquisitor was resisting him, the Intruder, every second with sheer willpower. Her mind was so firm that she had struggled to the very edge of waking by will alone!

This made Duncan realize that the exchange had to end quickly. After he passed on the necessary information, he needed to leave behind a mysterious image and withdraw calmly.

He did not plan to explain too much to her. He did not expect to make his friendly stance clear or build any trust with Vanna with just a few words. The conflict between “Captain Duncan” and a city-state Inquisitor was not something that could be solved by smooth talking. If he explained too much, he would only look more suspicious and might even draw Vanna’s attention toward unnecessary directions.

The spirit form flames spreading through the darkness slowly drew back. Duncan’s figure began to retreat in Vanna’s field of vision.

But in the last few seconds before the connection broke, Vanna still could not hold back her question: “What exactly are you plotting for Pland?!”

In the darkness, Duncan lifted his head. Suddenly, a strong streak of mischief rose in his heart.

He fixed his gaze on the young Inquisitor through the dream, the corners of his mouth slowly lifting. In the ghostly green light of the spirit form flames, Vanna heard the most absurd and baffling sentence she had ever heard since becoming an Inquisitor:

“Order some fries.”

The dream collapsed with a roar, and the connection was completely severed.

In the void of chaotic darkness, Duncan stepped back half a step and looked at the starlight before him, which was flickering unsteadily.

AI, now in the form of a skeletal pigeon, flew through the darkness and landed on his shoulder, flapping its wings.

“No matter what wild thoughts she has next, at least one thing is certain,” Duncan glanced at AI and murmured as if to himself. “The two key pieces of information—Sixth District and the small Cathedral—have now entered the field of view of Pland’s Storm Grand Cathedral. For whatever reason, they will definitely launch the highest-level investigation there.”

Duncan’s plan was simple and effective. All he needed was to pry the lid off that small Cathedral in the Sixth District and draw the attention of the Deep Sea Church over there. As for what Vanna and the priests behind her would think about everything afterward, that did not matter at all.

The greatest moving calamity on the Boundless Sea had personally come to an Inquisitor in a dream to report Heretic corruption inside the city-state. That alone was enough to make those priests ponder themselves to death. But before they finished puzzling it out, they would definitely throw all

their strength at that small Cathedral. By then, whatever secrets the Cathedral hid would be dug out by them.

Of course, during this investigation, Vanna might waste some effort because of the existence of the Vanished, but that was just a minor detail.

When he thought back to the little stunt he had pulled at the end of the dream, a faint smile appeared on Duncan's face.

"Order some fries?" AI, perched on his shoulder, noticed the smile and tilted its head. "Finely dice them for a topping?"

"…Your language is getting more and more broken," Duncan frowned. "Still, having some fries tomorrow morning is not a bad idea. I can use the chance to teach Alice how to make some proper food."

…

Vanna's eyes snapped open.

There was no lamp light in the room. Only the pale, cold glow of the World's Wound shone through the window into the bedroom. In the dim light, all the furnishings seemed covered in mottled shadows.

Her heart was pounding. It felt as if hot iron bars had been shoved into her skull. The dull ache from severe mental exhaustion and extreme tension pulsed between her two temple points. Her nightgown had been soaked with sweat and now clung cold and uncomfortable to her skin.

But this discomfort was nothing compared to that dream that had been invaded by corruption.

Vanna sat up in bed and carefully looked around. She slowly blinked a few times, then closed her eyes and opened them again.

Each time, her heart thumped hard twice. She was testing whether she had really shaken off that ghost captain's "phantom", yet she still feared that his

figure would appear in her field of vision the very next second.

Only after she confirmed that she had escaped the intrusion and that this was indeed the world of the Mortal Realm did she finally let out a long breath.

In all her years as an Inquisitor, she had rarely been this tense.

Vanna got out of bed and went to the dressing table not far away.

The dressing table stood there intact, and only her own reflection appeared in the mirror.

She stood in front of the mirror for several seconds, as if to check every detail in it. Then she shook her head hard, pulled open the drawer of the dressing table, and took out a Storm Rune Dagger carved with runes of storms and waves.

She held the Holy Relic, cut her skin, and let fresh blood soak into the runes. Then she offered a Prayer to the Storm Goddess.

In the short Prayer, she heard gentle waves sounding by her ear. The Goddess’s protection, as always, soothed her restless heart.

After reestablishing her connection with the Goddess, Vanna finally relaxed. Then she briskly changed out of her sweat-soaked nightclothes, put on clothes for going out as fast as she could, grabbed the greatsword by the bed, and pushed the door open to leave the room.

A short time later, a private car driven by a steam core broke the quiet of the Upper City center. Under the bright gas streetlamps, Vanna drove straight toward the Grand Cathedral.

She had to tell Bishop Valentine what had happened tonight as soon as possible, along with the strange things she had discovered in the archives

earlier. The situation was already far more complicated than expected. This was no longer an affair that Inquisitors alone could handle.

If necessary, Pland might even need to contact the Storm Grand Cathedral that was patrolling the Boundless Sea.

Vanna’s gaze was firm. Her breathing was steady. Her thoughts were clear.

But suddenly, a bit of hesitation rose in her heart again.

She recalled the strange scene at the very end of that dream.

Order some fries… what did that even mean?!

Chapter 168: Warnings Spreading

The sleepy Bishop Valentine saw Inquisitor Vanna rush into the Cathedral in the middle of the night, and the moment he heard her first words, the old man woke up completely.

“Captain Duncan entered your dream?!” Bishop Valentine stared at Vanna in shock. He even wondered if he was still half asleep. “That ghost captain came to you on his own… just to tell you a location and have you investigate it?”

“It is absolutely true, even though I know how unbelievable it sounds.” Vanna nodded hard. On her way here she had already guessed this would be his reaction, but there was nothing she could do. Her confusion was no lighter than Valentine’s. “The small cathedral in the Sixth District… I spoke very little with that ghost captain, and this was the most important information he revealed.”

The old bishop fell silent. In the quiet, he turned around and looked up at the statue of the Storm Goddess at the far end of the sanctuary. After who knew how long, he finally broke the silence in a low voice: “Vanna, do you remember the corruption you picked up at that cult ritual site in the sewers? After that, we carried out an emergency purification. Now it seems…”

“I understand what you mean.” Vanna drew a slow breath, her expression still calm. “Now it seems our purification never actually succeeded. The Vanished is still chasing me, and that ghost captain has already extended his power into my dreams.”

“Are you still clear-headed?” Valentine turned back, his gaze fixed quietly on Vanna’s eyes.

“I am clear-headed. I tested it on my way here. I can fully recite my own name and the Goddess’s name, and recite passages from the Storm Canon.” Vanna nodded. “For now, the corruption seems shallow. Only my dreams are affected. It has not yet spread to my body and actions in the Mortal Realm.”

“Shallow corruption that we still cannot pull out…” Valentine’s tone grew low, his eyes full of worry. “Like an irreversible countdown. And you are the Inquisitor of the Pland city-state. No one can take your place in the short term…”

Vanna understood what the old bishop was trying to say.

She had already suffered mental corruption from a high-level supernatural power. As the Church’s Inquisitor, this “fortress” of hers was already being slowly breached. A fortress about to fall was unreliable, because no one knew how far this corruption would go. No one knew whether the Vanna who woke up the next morning would still be Vanna. Right now she still served the Storm Goddess, but in the next second… no one knew whom she might be loyal to.

If it had been an ordinary guardian or a Father who suffered this kind of corruption, the problem would have been easy to handle. A period of confinement and an exorcism ritual were simple enough. Or, if the city-state were peaceful, she could have temporarily handed her duties to a Deputy and gone into the deepest part of the sanctuary to receive the highest-level “Sacred Quarantine” and “Divine purification”. But…

Now this “Inquisitor” was in an irreplaceable position. Even if they requested aid from the Storm Church headquarters, it would not solve the problem quickly.

“I cannot leave my post.” After a short silence, Vanna shook her head. She knew she was giving the old bishop a hard problem, but she had to keep fulfilling her duties. “I have a very bad feeling. We are facing a real, massive crisis. This crisis might not even come from the Vanished or the Sun fragment. An even greater shadow is lurking inside the city-state. At a time like this, I cannot hand the Inquisitor’s duties to anyone, not even to my most trusted Deputy.”

Valentine heard a different kind of seriousness in Vanna’s tone and immediately frowned slightly: “A crisis beyond the Vanished and the Sun fragment? Have you discovered something recently?”

“I have been investigating some things in the archives. I was actually planning to tell you tomorrow morning, but now it seems the situation is far more complicated than expected, and its urgency needs to be raised.” Vanna nodded, her face unusually serious. “I began to doubt the time node of the Sun fragment’s appearance in Pland. Based on that, I called up records from 1889 and earlier. In them I found a large number of heretic worship records. They were all marked as low urgency, but they were strange and very dense…”

As Vanna slowly explained, Bishop Valentine’s eyes opened wider and wider.

“These records were just lying quietly in our archives?” When Vanna finished, Valentine cried out, his face full of disbelief. “All this time, no one noticed? Not even that missing year, 1885…”

“No one noticed. It is as if someone ‘stole’ a part of our city-state. Certain obvious pieces of the Mortal Realm simply vanished from everyone’s sight.” Vanna spoke in a low voice. “And that kind of disappearance… does not look like something the Sun fragment could cause.”

Valentine tightened his grip on his scepter. His knuckles turned slightly white from the force.

“What connection do you think there is between this and the information ‘Captain Duncan’ passed to you in your dream?” he suddenly asked.

“I am not sure. First, stealing Mortal Realm from a city-state is not an ability of the Vanished. Second, if this really were the work of that ghost captain, he would have no reason to then corrupt my dreams just to tell me key clues. That does not match the rough and chaotic behavior style recorded about him.” Vanna analyzed calmly. “Unless… he suddenly changed his nature, turned into some vicious demon who plays with the world. Or…”

“Or what?”

“Or he became someone very concerned about the city-state’s safety. A warm-hearted citizen who comes to me to report any dangerous factor he sees.” Vanna spread her hands.

“Ahem, that is a Subspace-level joke.” Valentine coughed at once, then glared at Vanna. “Do not joke like this when you know you are already under the gaze of a high-level supernatural being. It makes me doubt your mental state.”

He thumped his chest a couple of times. After he steadied his breath, he again fixed his gaze on Vanna: “Besides you, who else knows about the anomaly you found in the archives?”

Vanna thought for a moment, then shook her head: “Only I know. I went to check on my own…”

She suddenly paused, as if her thoughts had snagged for a second, then shook her head again: “I went by myself to check the files.”

“Good… If there really is a conscious hand behind this, they probably have not noticed that their scheme has been exposed.” Valentine let out a breath, then had to admit she had been right just now. “You really cannot leave your post now… You must already have an investigation plan for those records, yes?”

“Yes. It includes coordinated actions with City Hall.”

“Start tomorrow. I will give you every support.” Valentine nodded at once. “In addition, I will also report what happened here to the Pope. I hope the great Storm Cathedral can provide us with some help…”

As he spoke, the old man thought for a few seconds, then asked: “Can you still pray normally to the Goddess?”

“Yes.” Vanna answered at once. “My connection with the Goddess has not been affected by that dream.”

Valentine frowned: “But the Goddess has not given any revelation or warning about your mental corruption?”

“…No.” Vanna hesitated, then still nodded in admission. “The Goddess has not warned me.”

Valentine rubbed his chin. After thinking deeply for a moment, he suddenly raised his head and fixed his gaze on Vanna again: “For the time being, you must come back to the Cathedral to rest every night. Do not sleep anywhere outside the Cathedral. Also, you must carry the Storm Canon with you at all times when you are out. And if, while you are outside, you feel anomalous drowsiness or fatigue, you must immediately go to the nearest cathedral. Can you do that?”

“I can.”

“…Sigh, I hope you will not think of this as some kind of harsh treatment or doubt.” The old bishop sighed. Even though Vanna agreed very firmly, he

still could not help explaining. “You cannot leave your post right now, and there is no priest in Pland ranked higher than you who can act as your ‘supervisor’. This is a necessary arrangement, made on the premise of keeping you able to perform your basic duties…”

“Do not worry, of course I understand.” Vanna showed a faint smile and instead comforted the old bishop before her. “I know as well as you what kind of dangerous things we are fighting. Compared to those seniors who died because they lacked experience and theory, we are already very fortunate to still be fighting under the protection of rules.”

She paused, then went on: “So, about the small cathedral in the Sixth District…”

“It must be investigated. No matter what purpose that ghost captain had in coming to you, we have to go and take a look at that cathedral.” Valentine nodded slowly. “And… when I tried to recall it just now, I could not even remember who is in charge there. It seems something really is wrong.”

“All right. I will personally lead a team there tomorrow.”

“Mm.” Valentine nodded slightly, then looked at Vanna with curiosity. “Aside from the matter of the small cathedral, what else did that ghost captain say to you?”

If he had not asked, it would have been better. The moment he did, Vanna’s expression turned strange.

Valentine asked: “…Why that look on your face?”

“He did say one more sentence. A very bizarre sentence.” Vanna’s face was full of hesitation. “I do not know whether we should take it seriously…”

“There is no ‘should’ about it. The more unbelievable something is, the more likely it is the key!” Valentine’s eyes widened at once. “What did he say?”

Vanna hesitated for two seconds, then finally let out a long breath and said very seriously: “Make some fries.”

Valentine: “…”

After a moment of silence, the old bishop finally spoke again: “Really?”

“Absolutely. As real as my faith in the Goddess.”

“…Ah. Then that really is… really a bit too unbelievable…”

Chapter 169: Stepping into the Veil

“Got it? Fries are made like this. It is very simple. Just make sure you neither burn them nor leave them half raw. You do not need to stick your face over the pot and stare the whole time, and you do not need to taste for salt. Remember?”

On the Vanished’s morning, Duncan stood in the kitchen, speaking very seriously as he guided a very nervous Alice. In the pot of oil in front of the two of them, still slightly pale fries rolled up and down in the hot oil, making a constant sizzling sound.

“I… I remember!” Alice stared unblinking at the boiling oil, one hand still gripping a kitchen knife. On the cutting board beside her lay potato chunks she had cut into terrible shapes. Those would become ingredients for other dishes.

Duncan looked at the pot, then at the doll beside it, and nodded slightly. In his heart he thought that such a simple task really should not be something this silly thing could mess up again. Then he noticed the knife in Alice’s hand and felt a little uncomfortable: “…Can you put the knife down first? When you finish cutting things, do not keep holding it.”

A cursed doll standing in the kitchen with a kitchen knife, radiating killing intent toward potatoes, was not a very lucky sight.

It felt as if the very next second the background music would switch to some scary track, and a blood-red health bar would pop up above Alice’s head, stabbing right out of the screen.

“Oh… oh!” Alice finally reacted. She hurriedly put the knife back on the side, then waved at the captain with great confidence. “Captain, you can go back now! I already learned this. You and AI just wait to eat!”

Duncan stared at Alice for quite a while. After he was sure this doll really was not going to make any more trouble, he finally relaxed a little. At the same time, a feeling of emotion rose in his heart.

After all this time, the Vanished could finally produce fries steadily.

…

On the second floor of the antique shop, at the dining table, Nina, who had a medical patch stuck on her forehead, raised her head curiously and glanced at her uncle: “Uncle, I have wanted to ask. You have been frowning all morning… and just now you suddenly looked like you relaxed and let out a breath…”

“Did I? I did not notice…” Duncan froze for a moment. His attention crossed the vast distance in an instant and fell back into this little antique shop. Then he smiled and shook his head. “It is nothing. I just remembered some numbers in the account book and did some mental math. I just worked it out.”

“Oh.” Nina nodded. “That makes sense. I thought your nerves were all tight just now.”

Duncan did not answer. He kept his calm smile, but in his heart he could not help muttering a line: [This young lady’s observation skills are pretty sharp.]

At this time Nina leaned forward and glanced at the small window at the end of the second-floor corridor that faced the street. After hesitating for a moment, she whispered: “Shirley did not come today.”

“…She has her own place to live.” Duncan looked at the young lady in front of him, whose face now showed a bit of loneliness. “And you still have to go to school today. How would you have time to go out and play with her?”

“I should have asked where she lives.” Nina spoke again. “Then when she does not have time to come find me, I can go find her.”

Duncan did not say anything at first. After two or three seconds of silence, he asked softly: “Do you like this new friend that much? You actually have not spent that much time together.”

“Shirley is really nice. She even saved my life in the City Museum.” Nina answered at once. “And… and…”

“And what?”

“And when she was staying here, I chatted with her and Dog at night and asked about her. I found out she has always only had Dog with her. They live in a little alley in the shantytown. At night there are not even proper streetlights there. The house lets in wind and rain, and I…”

“Nina.” Duncan suddenly interrupted the girl in front of him, his expression a little serious. “Friendship cannot be built on pity. That is even more true for a child like Shirley.”

Nina froze, then raised her head to meet Duncan’s eyes. After a moment she slowly scratched the hair at her temple. “Uncle, you suddenly said something very philosophical…”

Duncan: “…”

“But you did remind me. I might be a little bit sympathetic.” Nina went on. “But… I just want her to live better. I can feel it. Even though she was always strangely nervous when she was living here, she was actually very

happy. I… if I make this kind of judgment for her, am I being a bit self-righteous?”

Duncan did not answer. He seemed to fall into brief thought. After a moment he smiled and shook his head. “Do not think so much. Next time we see Shirley, we will ask where she lives. As for now… hurry and finish eating. It is almost time for school.”

“Okay!” Nina nodded obediently. Then, as if something had suddenly occurred to her, excitement lit up her face. “Right, does that mean today I can… ride that new bicycle to school?”

“No.” Duncan lifted his eyelids and refused without hesitation. “Did you forget how badly you fell yesterday?”

As he spoke, the scene from yesterday after Nina came home rose in his mind. The girl’s first glance had landed on the brand-new bicycle parked on the first floor. She had almost jumped in place from excitement, then rushed to climb on and try it. After about thirty seconds, there was a loud crash, and she fell at the doorway…

She still had a patch on her forehead now.

“I… I thought riding a bicycle would be easy.” Nina lowered her head in embarrassment. “I saw that my classmates can all…”

Duncan sighed.

He really should have thought of it. If there had never been a bicycle in the antique shop and Nina had not had any friends for so many years, how could she possibly have had the chance to learn to ride? When he bought the bicycle, he had completely ignored this point.

“Take the bus to school today. Do not run there. Our family does not lack this little bit of fare now.” Duncan took a few coins out of his pocket and put them in front of Nina. “When you come back, I will teach you how to

ride. It really is not hard. With how clever you are, you will probably learn it in a few days."

Nina was a little dejected at first, but soon she became cheerful again and nodded happily. "Oh!"

After a while, Nina ran out through the front door of the antique shop. Duncan stood at the small window on the second floor of the shop, watching the girl's figure cross the street in the morning light and run toward the bus stop not far away.

More and more carriages, traffic, and street noises were echoing through the alleys. This district was slowly waking up in the sunlight. Golden-red sunlight spread along the distant rooflines, like a shimmering, rising Veil.

A Veil of flame that swept across the entire city-state.

Duncan's expression suddenly froze. He frowned and fixed his gaze on the dense rows of houses in the distance.

The majestic scene of the flaming Veil sweeping across the city-state vanished from the glow of the clouds, as if the image that had just flashed into his mind had been a baseless illusion.

Yet the deep crease between Duncan's brows did not relax at all. He just kept staring into the distance, as if trying to find another layer of Mortal Realm overlapping behind that magnificent dawn.

Only after several minutes did he slowly pull his gaze back.

He focused for a moment, then beckoned toward the empty air beside him: "AI."

In the next second, a ball of ghost-green flame burst suddenly in the air. An undead bird coiled out of the fire and took shape. AI flapped her wings and

landed on Duncan’s shoulder, burping loudly as she shouted: “Burp… who is calling… burp… the fleet?”

Duncan’s mood broke apart at once. He turned his head and stared, dumbfounded, at the pigeon that looked almost twice as plump as before. “…How much did you eat on the ship?”

AI flapped her wings and stretched her neck as far as it would go. “The hour of feasting has come… burp!”

Duncan looked at the bird without expression. After a moment he sighed. “No wonder Alice was fussing over there for so long and still brought so little food into the cabin. So you intercepted it all… Fine, we will call it not wasting food. Can you still fly? Head to the Sixth District.”

The pigeon let out a loud squawk at once: “Mission accepted! Mission accepted!”

In the next second, there was a flash of fire at the small window on the second floor of the antique shop. The swollen fat pigeon leaped out of the window and wobbled away through the air in the direction of the Sixth District.

At the same time, deep in the Sixth District, two dark gray steam cars were moving along an empty, chilly street.

The tall Vanna sat in the back seat of one of the cars. Her greatsword rested at her side, and she was quietly using her gaze to watch the scene on the street outside.

Because she was not sure what state that small cathedral was in, Vanna had not driven an eye-catching steam walker directly into the area. Instead, she had chosen to personally lead a small elite unit in quietly first, while the support team waited on standby in the nearby neighborhoods.

After entering the Sixth District, she had indeed sensed the “atmosphere” here at once… and it felt very wrong.

A community that was far too lacking in vitality. Residents who were sparse, lazy, and slow to react to outside stimuli. Old facilities that were long out of repair, even beyond what the Lower City’s bottom line should allow.

An aura lingered over everything. The entire district gave her the feeling… that time had frozen in a crack that the world had forgotten.

Chapter 170: Loosening

After a long time, Vanna finally pulled her gaze back from the car window.

Her main purpose in coming here today was to investigate that small cathedral, but after she entered the Sixth District, she already felt that the atmosphere of the whole area was not quite right. It made her faintly feel… that maybe every inch of this neighborhood needed to be investigated.

After thinking for a moment, she reached out and picked up a thick stack of papers from the seat beside her.

She had requested these files from City Hall before this operation. Using her authority as an Inquisitor and the relevant articles in the Special Execution Regulations for Anomaly Cases, she had obtained all the municipal records related to the Sixth District from the past few years. On the way here, she had already read part of them.

These documents from City Hall were not top secret, nor did they involve any high?level supernatural case, cold case, or major case. On the contrary, what Vanna had asked for was the simplest, most basic kind of information —

Gas meter readings, electricity payments, shop taxes, water supply, heating, garbage collection, security patrols…

Pages rustled as Vanna’s eyes swept quickly over the documents.

If the past few years as an Inquisitor had taught her any “case?handling experience”, one rule was absolutely vital—

The faint traces of supernatural Visions were often hidden in the most ordinary scenes of everyday life.

The Boundless Sea watched on all sides. Anomalies and Visions filled the Mortal Realm. Under the gaze of these things that threatened all living beings, the peaceful “daily life” inside the city?states was the greatest treasure in this world. The ordinary people of Pland might have already taken their peaceful days for granted, but those warriors who fought Anomalies and Visions year after year knew very well—

A shaft of sunlight in the morning, a hot meal on the table, a hawker calling on the street, and a good?night said before sleep—these were all unbroken chains of sacred miracles.

They were the grand scene Mortals had spent ten thousand years building in this crumbling world.

Any disturbance from an supernatural Vision would leave a scratch on that scene.

The Guardian at the wheel spoke from the front of the car. This young Church warrior had noticed the slight frown on Vanna’s face and asked: “Did you find something wrong? Are the municipal records missing?”

“On the contrary. All the municipal records are complete,” Vanna shook her head lightly. “The water, power, gas, heating, and sewage logs are all here, and they all stay at very even values—suspiciously reasonable.”

“Then your expression…”

“There are no public security cases,” Vanna lifted her eyelids slightly. “The section for public security is completely blank. Also, the records of newborns are blank, and the records of resident deaths are blank as well.”

The Guardian driving widened his eyes a little. In the rearview mirror, Vanna could see the look of disbelief on the young man’s face.

“A clear Anomaly, isn’t it,” Vanna said softly. “One neighborhood, all these years. The population neither rises nor falls. No public security cases at all, not even a single fistfight. Even the safest part of the Upper City can’t reach that level. Yet all the water, power, gas, and heating records are there. It feels as if…”

She paused and looked out the window: “As if all the residents here are a herd of tame phantoms… They live quietly inside this fenced?off place, neither increasing nor decreasing. There is no conflict inside, no contact with the outside. They only go on calmly consuming resources, sending a regular signal back to City Hall that says, ‘Everything is normal here.’ And yet, even though it is so wrong, no one has paid attention to it for so many years.”

The car fell silent. Only the dull sound of the steam core running could be heard. After an unknown time, Vanna suddenly felt the car jolt.

“We’ve arrived at the small cathedral.”

Vanna raised her head and saw, right outside the car window, the community cathedral that had somehow slipped out of the “view” of the main cathedral.

From the outside, it looked as if it had been abandoned for more than ten years.

This was the place that terrifying ghost captain had pointed out to her.

In her mind, she could not help seeing again those burning ghostly flames and that gloomy, majestic figure frozen at the center of her vision. In the next second, she took a deep breath, softly recited the holy name of the Storm Goddess Gamona F, picked up her weapon, pushed the door open, and stepped out of the car.

A bleak, cold wind blew from the end of the street, lifting the dry fallen leaves by the roadside. The black?clad Guardians followed beside the Inquisitor, cautiously closing in on the abandoned small cathedral.

The fallen leaves cracked softly underfoot, sounding like fire burning rotten wood, crackling and popping.

Suddenly the sound of flapping wings came from above. Amid the swirling leaves, Vanna looked up and saw a White Dove flutter down and land on the cathedral’s spire.

The dove tilted its head, as if curiously casting a gaze on the Guardians spreading out around the area.

“A White Dove… a good omen for calm seas…” For some reason, this odd thought flashed through Vanna’s mind. Then she ignored the dove that had suddenly flown in, stepped forward, and gently pushed open the half?closed doors of the small cathedral.

Warm, bright light filled her vision. A Nun with a gentle smile on her face appeared before her.

“Hello, Sister. It has been a long time since anyone came to this cathedral…”

The Nun’s soft voice reached the ears of the Guardian warriors.

…

One gas lamp after another stood in neat rows between the shelves. Their bright light drove away the Shadows among the ancient files. Heavy, slow footsteps echoed between the shelves, mixed with the old priest’s low muttering:

“Row seven, column six, row seven, column six… The records for 1885 should be here… they should be here…”

The old priest stopped in front of the shelf. He looked up and saw the shelf towering over him like a giant, silently gazing down. The files that carried the city?state's memories of history were arranged neatly in the giant's bones and flesh.

His gaze fell on several of the folders, and he slowly reached out his hand.

His brass clockwork prosthetic gave off a slightly rusty, grinding sound as it moved.

"Finally found it!" The old priest's eyes suddenly lit up, and he could not hide the excitement in his voice. "So it was hidden here… We searched for so long before, when I was looking together with Inquisitor Vanna!"

His fingers touched those few files.

Heavy, slow footsteps echoed between the shelves, mixed with the old priest's low muttering: "Row seven, column six, row seven, column six…"

"Finally found it!" The old priest's eyes suddenly lit up. He reached toward those files. His brass clockwork prosthetic creaked with a rusty grinding noise. "So it was hidden here. We looked for it for so long before, when I searched together with the Inquisitor!"

His fingers were just about to touch those files.

Heavy, slow footsteps echoed between the shelves.

…

The old priest suddenly stopped walking.

He lifted his head, his neck stiff as if it had rusted. He quietly cast his gaze over the huge shelves stretching out in neat rows ahead. One gas lamp after another burned between them, and the pillars carved with wave patterns stood silently among the shelves.

A gentle sound of waves suddenly rose in his heart, making the old man's cloudy mind clear for a moment.

"The archive's wards have been activated? Who activated them? Why? Was it me? When did I activate these wards? What am I doing here?"

The old priest shivered, and instinctively reached for the large?caliber revolver at his waist. The next second, he noticed something strange about his body.

The arm that had once moved so freely had somehow become stiff and heavy. The screech of grinding parts sounded like a pile of scrap metal that had been left to rust for years, crushing against itself.

Startled, he looked at the arm that had been replaced with a brass clockwork prosthetic, and saw only a limb covered in patches of rust. Verdigris and foul fluid seeped from the metal seams and stained the whole arm. As his gaze moved down, he saw his tattered clothes and a left leg that kept leaking black machine oil.

It was as if he had been trudging through this archive for years.

The old priest stared blankly at the marks on his body. The memories that had been sealed away finally loosened a little. He suddenly remembered many things, so distant they felt like they had happened in a past life—an Inquisitor visiting, investigating records, strange logs of Heretic worship, entire years that had vanished…

Then the Inquisitor had left the archive, while he stayed behind to keep searching for the missing records of 1885…

The gentle sound of waves rose again, clearer than before, yet still as if it came through a thick Veil, from another time and space.

But that distant, hazy sound of waves made the old priest's mind even clearer than before. As his memories loosened, his reason and judgment

rushed back. In the next second, he realized what might be happening.

A vast Vision—not some single Anomaly, not a single malicious supernatural being, not a mastermind hiding behind the scenes, nor one isolated supernatural phenomenon, but a vast, all?encompassing Vision!

The city?state of Pland was right at the center of this gigantic Vision!

“This is bad!”

The old priest cried out and turned, dragging his no?longer?nimble body as he ran toward his post.

The next second, he forced himself to a halt.

A strange black figure had appeared in the archive without him knowing when.

Inside this enclosed room, that eerie figure was holding a bizarre Black Parasol, as if to block some sunlight that was nowhere to be seen.

Chapter 171: The Fork in History

The figure was tall, even a bit taller than Inquisitor Vanna. The figure was thin, as if the black long coat wrapped only a withered strip of flesh. In this closed room he held a big umbrella, its lowered canopy hiding the intruder’s face. Yet with just one glance, the old priest could see profane, twisted Shadows clinging to that body.

“The Black Sun’s dregs?” The old man stared at the figure in shock, then roared in anger: “You dare step into this holy archive!”

The next second, a loud bang shattered the archive’s silence. The old priest had already drawn the large?caliber revolver at his waist. The bullet, blessed by divine blessing, roared out with fire and thunder. But perhaps the old man’s body was too slow. Before the shot rang out, the figure had already moved. Two blurry shadows sprang from the hem of his coat. The first shadow blocked the bullet in midair. The other crossed ten meters in an instant and lashed the old priest’s shoulder.

A harsh screech of metal scraping rang out as the old priest’s body flew sideways and slammed into a nearby shelf. The huge shelf shook violently, and countless books and files tumbled down.

The strange black figure with the umbrella took a step and walked toward where the old priest had fallen. A low, chaotic muttering came from within its body, sounding like foul flesh rolling and boiling in a pot.

Yet in the next second, a furious shout came from the pile of fallen books, and the old priest leaped out of it. A sharp steel sword had appeared in his

hand at some point. The sword whistled through the air as it slashed swiftly toward the figure that had invaded the archive.

The intruder stopped abruptly. The Black Umbrella tilted slightly and blocked the fierce strike. Sparks burst from the clash between steel and the umbrella ribs. The old priest rolled as he landed, and his longsword did not pause. It arced in a tight circle and came slanting in from another angle, cutting toward the intruder’s side!

The longsword spun and swung, iron rang on iron, and the old man’s mechanical limbs let out a low, hoarse roar. After many years of silence, the Storm Swordsmanship he had honed for decades once again showed its might. Continuous spinning and sweeping slashes poured toward the profane enemy like waves that would not cease. Between each arc traced by the blade, faint phantom waves took shape layer by layer. Those phantom waves grew more solid and heavy, and at last began to carry the impact and force of real surf!

The Storm Goddess’s power filled the unending arc strikes. The heavy pressure of the waves poured into the specially forged steel sword. Every cut came down with the tang of sea wind, making the air and the floor around them tremble.

The intruder’s Black Umbrella was unnaturally hard and did not budge under more than a dozen slashes, but the figure holding it kept retreating. Under the piling impact of the waves, it was forced back step by step to the edge of a nearby shelf. Faint, irritated growls and whispers came from within its body, full of a charm that could unsettle the mind.

But the old priest had already sealed off all unnecessary senses and paid no attention at all to the noise the intruder made. He knew his attacks must not stop. Storm Swordsmanship required continuous pressure, like waves that could not break in the middle. And the “dregs” split off from the Sunspawn

all carried power that could not be underestimated. If his suppression faltered for even a moment, the enemy would slip free of the fight in the very next second.

At the same time, the old priest's heart was full of shock and doubt. How had this profane scrap slipped into the archive? This cathedral was saturated with the Goddess's power. It held countless mechanisms and wards, with over a dozen layers of open and hidden guards from inside to out. Even the Sunspawn itself would be blocked if it came in person. How could they have failed to notice the intrusion of a single "dreg"?

"Could it be… that this dreg did not enter the cathedral through normal space and time?"

Just then, a sharp sound of something cutting through the air suddenly rang out. Every muscle in the old priest's body tensed at once. As a seasoned warrior, he reacted instantly. His longsword did not stop, only shifted its angle a little, ready to meet the intruder's sneak attack.

A sharp pain shot up from his side.

The unbroken flow of sword light stopped. The old priest stared in shock at the tentacle that had pierced his body. Blood slowly dripped from the hem of his ragged clothes. His brass prosthetic limb radiated scorching heat, and the heavily worn, rusted gears inside gave out one last burst of noise before grinding to a halt with a squeal.

Only after another second did the old priest realize what had happened—he had grown old.

He, and all the gears in his body, had grown old.

With a disgusting sound, the ugly tentacle slowly withdrew back into the intruder's clothes. The inhuman thing slowly approached the old man, who was still using his longsword to support himself and barely remained

standing. It lowered the Black Umbrella and revealed a “head” that kept swelling and shrinking, changing shape like a blooming flower of flesh. A hoarse voice came from its “pistil”.

It was Common Speech, barely recognizable:

“Go tell your god that this ugly age is over. The Sun will rise again from history…”

“History…” The old priest’s body trembled. He had not yet fallen, but he no longer had the strength to lift his sword. All at once, he understood: “You have corrupted history?!”

The intruder seemed to laugh. Though it was only a blooming flower of flesh, a hint of mockery still seemed to show in its trembling “petals” and crooked teeth: “On the day the great fire rose, everyone’s wishes were fulfilled.”

The old priest slowly lowered his head. Life quickly drained from his aged body. He seemed at last to give up his struggle in the mortal world and quietly wait for the final moment to come.

The intruder seemed rather bored by this outcome. It raised the umbrella again, ready to leave.

Yet in the very next second, a thunderous grinding of metal suddenly rang out. From the mechanical prosthetics that had completely stopped came once more the sound of gears turning and oil pumps building pressure. The intruder turned its head in shock and saw only a flash of sword light rushing toward it.

“Please bear witness!”

The old priest let out a roar. The steel sword slashed at the intruder’s body without the slightest hesitation. This time there was no Black Umbrella to block it, and no tentacle to interfere. The blade, carrying all of his

remaining strength, sliced through the enemy almost like tearing a strip of cloth.

Caught off guard, the intruder was cut in two by a single stroke. The two halves of its body fell to the floor.

But in the very next second, each half of the severed body began to emit a sickening squirm of flesh. Countless tiny tendrils sprouted from within, spreading outward as they groped for each other and began to fuse back together.

The intruder slowly reshaped itself, and low, angry growls came from deep inside it.

But the old priest had already lowered his sword, and his body slowly toppled to the floor. With his cloudy eyes, he watched the intruder stand up again bit by bit, and a look of relief appeared on his face.

He knew that even his last strength could not kill this monster. Even as a dreg, it was still a dreg of the Sunspawn, far beyond what a dying, aged Guardian with only a steel sword could truly oppose. But at least, before his death, he had proved his loyalty to the Goddess.

The Storm had borne witness. It could end now.

The intruder stood up again. In its anger, tendrils thick with corruption spread from its body, and rows of sharp teeth jutted from the edges of those tendrils.

In the old priest’s sight, he saw flames rise up behind the intruder. Fire spread through the archive. The entire cathedral burned in a roaring blaze.

The statue of the Goddess collapsed in the distance with a crash.

A Pland completely consumed by flames appeared in his vision. A History Branch where a shard of the Sun had successfully descended and all of

Pland’s Guardians had been wiped out unfolded before his eyes.

The old man’s consciousness sank slowly into this History Branch born of corruption. Yet suddenly, out of the corner of his eye, he saw something else.

A tuft of ghostly green fire was spreading discreetly through the blazing inferno, flowing along the seams between light and shadow, along the phantoms rising in the flames. The green flames split and flowed everywhere.

Behind a collapsed shelf nearby, a small tongue of green flame seemed to suddenly “catch a scent”. It sprang forward like a hound that had found its prey, pouncing on the intruder just as it was about to deliver the final blow.

The old priest watched all of this in a daze. His consciousness was already drifting between reality and illusion, and he could hardly tell whether what he saw belonged to the Mortal Realm or was only a hallucination. He saw the intruder suddenly wrapped in green flames. The body that held the power of the Sunspawn melted like wax. He heard its dying screams echo through the entire archive, filled with unbelievable madness and terror.

Then everything went quiet.

The sea of fire faded. The corrupted history withdrew for the moment back into the depths of the Veil. The archive, wedged between two History Branches, fell into dead silence. No one visited. No one came.

Only an old man who had died with his sword in hand lay quietly on the floor. His half?open eyes stared toward the distance. In one eye was the reflection of a Pland that had survived in peace. In the other was the reflection of the History Branch where the Sun had destroyed the world.

But he no longer belonged to either one. He had neither died in that great fire, nor survived it.

Cooling blood flowed from beneath the old priest’s body. As if guided by a powerful will, the blood crept quietly over the floor, gathering into a trail of footprints that slowly extended toward the nearby Administrator console…

Chapter 172: Vanna’s Discovery

Vanna stood quietly at the stairs leading down to the underground sanctum, looking at the black door that had just restored itself before everyone’s eyes.

Three hours earlier, she had led her team to this abandoned cathedral. Inside, she saw warm and bright lamplight, a main hall that looked completely normal, a nun quietly at prayer, and a clean and tidy pulpit.

Two hours earlier, she had shaken off that obviously strange “nun”, led the Guardians to find the underground sanctum, and, after opening the sanctum door, finally seen the truth inside—an underground space buried in darkness, a sword-wielding nun who seemed to have fallen in battle only a short time ago, battle marks all over the cellar, and no sign at all of the intruders.

Two minutes earlier, she had finished a careful search of the underground sanctum. Together with her subordinates, she had carried the nun’s body out, planning to send it to the central cathedral for an autopsy and burial.

Then, once the nun’s body was brought outside the sanctum, it turned into ash in front of everyone and scattered on the wind. At the same time, the basement door that had been violently pried open two hours ago returned in a blink to its original state. Now it stood quietly at the end of the stairs, as if mocking the explorers standing on the steps.

“Inquisitor…” A Guardian warrior with a short beard stepped close to Vanna’s side, his voice low. “There seems to be some kind of space-time loop here…”

Vanna nodded lightly and said nothing.

What rose up in her mind instead was last night's horrifying dream, and Captain Duncan, who had invaded and corrupted that dream.

The ghost captain's words in the dream echoed in her head: "If you truly care about the safety of the city-state, you might as well go to the Sixth District and take a look at that small cathedral…

"I am very curious what you will find there…"

Was this what that "Captain Duncan" had wanted her to see? A sealed loop of time and space, a small cathedral corrupted and cut off by some unknown power, and a nun who died fighting mysterious intruders? Why did he want her to see these things? What did everything here mean?

Vanna frowned hard. When she set out this morning, her mind had been full of the Vanished and whatever scheme that ghost captain might be hiding. She had wondered if guiding her to this small cathedral was some way to corrupt or attack her as an Inquisitor. But now she suddenly began to doubt that first judgment.

Could it be… that the ghost captain really only wanted to give her a clue? Like some eager passerby… reporting a heretic in the city-state to her?

This thought surfaced in Vanna's mind. Not long ago, she had said the same thing to Bishop Valentine in a joking tone. But now she could not help running that joke through her mind again, a joke so absurd it reached the level of Subspace.

The next second, the young Inquisitor shivered, and her expression sharpened.

She was actually starting to think about that ghost captain in a "harmless" way. This had to be the effect of his mental corruption! She must not let herself go down that path…

“Inquisitor?” Her subordinate’s voice sounded again beside her, waking Vanna from her daze. The short-bearded Guardian looked quite worried. “Did you… hear or see something?”

“…No. My mind is very clear.” Vanna shook her head and spoke to this rather reliable subordinate. She knew this man had met with Bishop Valentine before they set out, and that he was likely carrying the task of “watching” her, his own commander. She felt no resentment at all about this —after all, she had suffered corruption from Captain Duncan. At a time like this, even going on a mission in chains would have been normal.

“The time and space here have reset. Should we go down and look again?” the subordinate asked.

Vanna thought for a moment, then turned her head and asked: “What is the ‘nun’ in the main hall doing now?”

“She is still at prayer,” a Guardian who had just returned from the main hall answered at once. “It seems nothing we do outside the main hall can draw her attention.”

“Good.” Vanna nodded slightly. Her gaze fell on the door at the end of the stairs. After a long pause, she bit her lip. “We are going down again.”

She led the Guardians back to the entrance of the underground sanctum and pushed the door once more, feeling the familiar resistance. The door was being held from the other side. It was the nun’s body.

Last time, she had told her subordinate to pry the hinges with a crowbar and open a path while damaging the door’s runes as little as possible.

This time, she placed her hand on the door panel, took a soft breath, then suddenly clenched her hand into a fist and knocked once, very fast.

In a hundredth of a second, the whole door trembled in a way no human senses could catch. Then the sturdy door suddenly shattered into endless

dust. Wood splinters and metal powder drifted down and were blown aside by the aura swirling around Vanna.

The nun’s body toppled from behind the door. She had no extra damage beyond the wounds she already carried.

Only then did the Guardians at the scene hear a very deep hum. It spread as if it were drilling into their brains, then faded again in a blink.

The warriors turned awed gazes toward the young Inquisitor, but Vanna was used to such looks. With a long sword on her back, she drew the consecrated lantern from her belt with her left hand and stepped forward as soon as the door burst apart.

The glow of the consecrated lantern lit the dark underground space once again. Everything she saw was exactly the same as the first time she had come in. As expected, time and space here had already returned to the starting point.

After another detailed search, Vanna and the warriors returned to the fallen nun’s side.

Not long ago, Vanna had tried to carry this nun’s body out of the underground sanctum. Now she already understood that this body was probably like the warped time and space here. It had become part of the closed loop and could no longer leave this place.

She let her gaze rest quietly on the nun’s bloodstained face. Vanna did not know how long she stayed lost in thought before she suddenly whispered: “You are still fighting in this looping time and space…”

The underground sanctum fell into a brief silence, until a Guardian’s voice suddenly broke it: “Inquisitor, what do you think… she was really fighting against?”

Vanna thought quietly. After a long time, she raised her head with a thoughtful look and began to lay out the information point by point:

“The underground sanctum is an excellent place for a seal. Once the door closes, it becomes a cage.

“The cathedral’s Guardian unit is missing, and it is clear they did not take part in the battle in the underground sanctum.

“The nun locked herself in here and came in carrying a weapon. That means she already foresaw a battle before she entered.

“There are no traces of intruders here. But if time and space here form a closed loop, the intruders should also be trapped in that loop. No matter how fast they ran, in the instant we opened the door, they could not have had time to erase every trace…”

The Guardians beside her listened to each point their commander made. One of them suddenly reacted: “A cleric only seals themself in like that and prepares for a ‘final battle’ in one case…”

“Yes. Only one case.” Vanna spoke softly and slowly stood up. “When a cleric discovers that a gate to Subspace is about to open inside their own soul.”

“Subspace invasion!” a Guardian gasped in a low voice. “What she was fighting here… was her own shadow?! But… but how is that possible? This is a cathedral, and…”

“And no one received any alarm from this cathedral,” Vanna cut in before the subordinate could finish. She knew very well how many things were wrong here. “A cleric who is completely corrupted by Subspace becomes a vessel and opens a gate to Subspace inside their soul. But that process usually takes time. In a place like this cathedral, even if things were urgent, the watchers here should have had a chance to send out an alarm. Yet it

seems the corruption that struck this nun advanced very fast… so fast that she only had time to grab a sword and lock herself in here…”

She paused, then went on, thinking aloud: “…It is also possible the alarm was sent, but because of Subspace interference, it never reached beyond the cathedral.”

“…But this is not a ship sailing at sea,” a nearby Guardian warrior muttered in disbelief. “We are on land. The cathedral is under wide protection. How could Subspace power corrupt a priest so quickly and also cut off all contact with the outside for this whole area?”

“You are right. It does not make sense. Nothing here makes sense. But even stranger is this…” Vanna said softly as she looked around the underground sanctum. The light of the consecrated lantern shone over the dark walls and pillars. In the shifting light and shadow, it felt as if countless evil secrets hid there. “If Subspace once corrupted this place, then where did it go?”

Chapter 173: The Fire Spreads

Subspace corruption did not fade on its own, just as justice did not enforce itself. After so many years fighting the twisted Shadows in the deep layers of the world, Vanna knew this very well.

If this cathedral had once been corrupted by Subspace, and the duty nun here had already fallen to that corruption, then the thing that had invaded this place would never simply vanish on its own. Taking into account the eerie “afterimage” nun in the main hall and the wrong atmosphere hanging over the entire Sixth District, it was clear that the door of the underground sanctum had not stopped the intruders here. So… where had the invading Subspace power gone?

Vanna raised the consecrated lantern in her hand. The Whale Oil, filled with holy power, burned quietly inside the lamp. Wherever its glow spread, everything in the underground sanctum came into her sight. The blade slashes and bullet marks all over the walls were like words carved again and again by the closed loop of time, calmly telling her their secrets.

…Words?

Vanna suddenly frowned, as if a flash of lightning had gone off in her heart.

If this nun, who died in the underground sanctum, had already seen her fate when she closed the door, would she have tried to leave some kind of record, to warn whoever came to investigate later?

That was how a well-trained cleric should react!

“Check this place again,” she lifted her head and ordered the warriors loudly beside her. “Every mark. Sword cuts, bullet marks, bloodstains, all of it—this sister very likely left some kind of message before she died!”

“Yes!”

The Guardians moved at once. Each of them held a consecrated lantern as they spread out and began an even more detailed, more focused search of the underground sanctum they had already swept once.

Vanna did not stand idle either. Once she realized the fallen nun might have left a message before her death, she went back to where the nun had died, back to the entrance of the underground sanctum, and carefully checked the floor and walls near the door.

She had just destroyed the sanctum door, but she was sure there would be no message on it. The sanctum door was part of a precise seal, with the holy symbols of the Goddess carved into it. Leaving marks on it would weaken the sanctum’s protection. The nun would never do that.

The sword-bearing nun still lay quietly on the ground. Blood that had not yet clotted slowly flowed beneath her.

Vanna crouched beside the body and examined the nun from head to toe. Then, based on the angle at which the nun had fallen when they forced the door, she guessed her posture and position at the time of death. She bent down at the most likely angle, pried open the nun’s clenched hand, and checked the condition of the sword.

Suddenly, her movements stopped.

Vanna’s gaze fell on the ground beside the nun.

There was a row of sword marks there. At first glance they looked like a messy scrawl, as if someone at the edge of death had scratched the ground with an unsteady blade.

In their earlier inspections, Vanna and her subordinates had all overlooked them. This time, the young Inquisitor finally realized that these seemingly chaotic scratches were actually a kind of “message”, badly distorted and carved over and over again.

“Over here.” She lifted her head and called loudly to the searching Guardians. Then she lowered her eyes again and carefully tried to read the information hidden in the sword marks.

She stared for a long time before she finally picked out a few characters:

“1885.”

It was only a line of numbers.

The Guardians had gathered beside her now. Standing at Vanna’s side, they too managed to see the numbers in the sword marks. The short-bearded Guardian in the lead clearly did not understand what they meant. He looked at his commander in confusion. “Inquisitor, these numbers… Inquisitor?”

He saw the shock on Vanna’s face. The moment she saw the numbers, her eyes widened as if thunder had exploded in her heart. Even this Inquisitor, who always showed a calm and steady face to her subordinates, could not control her expression.

Vanna snapped back to herself at her subordinate’s call. She drew in a sharp breath and felt her heart pounding. The memories of searching through the archive alone rose up again. She remembered those strange records of heretic worship, the files reaching back from 1889, and the missing records for 1885…

All these memories finally gathered on this underground sanctum and on the messy sword marks before her: 1885.

“1885… She used her last strength to tell us that she actually died in 1885…”

Vanna muttered to herself under her breath. The Guardians beside her looked at each other. One of them frowned. “But why would she go out of her way to stress that?”

“To prove she did not die in 1889…” Vanna answered without thinking, but stopped halfway and showed the same baffled look on her face. “Right… why would she stress that year? If she died in 1885, there is no way she could know there would be another disaster in the city-state four years later…”

The young Inquisitor sank into confusion. Many clues had already surfaced, and they seemed about to merge into one whole. But right in the middle, a huge gap yawned open, and she could not bridge her thoughts.

If the numbers this nun left were meant to show the year of her death, then that year had to have a special meaning. The “warning” she wanted to send had to be hidden in that year. But… what warning could have such a strong link to the year 1885?

Did this nun see something in her final moments? Had she already foreseen that the records for 1885 would vanish from the archive of the central cathedral? Or did she know why those records would disappear?

Sadly, the truth had faded with her cooling blood. The moment the underground sanctum’s door closed, the secrets this nun knew were doomed to be lost. All she could send across time and space to Vanna with her life was this hard-to-read line of numbers.

Vanna looked up and saw the Guardians focusing their gazes on her. In several of those eyes there was not only concern, but also careful watchfulness.

“I visited the archive at the central cathedral earlier,” she said to her subordinates after ordering her thoughts. “In the archive, all records from

1885 were gone for some reason. It seems that this year is definitely…”

She suddenly stopped.

The scenes of searching the archive rose again in her mind for no clear reason, as if some other force kept urging her to recall them. She remembered herself walking again and again between the huge shelves, and between these images she suddenly heard the gentle sound of waves.

Vanna slowly opened her eyes wider.

She still could not recall anything other than reading files alone, but she already knew that something might be wrong with her memories of the archive. Her Spiritual Insight gift was warning her. The Goddess was warning her too!

“Back to the central cathedral,” she suddenly said to the subordinate beside her. “I need to go to the archive!”

The Guardians looked at each other, not sure at first why the Inquisitor had become so tense and grim. But they did not hesitate for long and accepted her order at once.

Just as the Guardians were about to leave, one of them glanced down at the ground beside him and suddenly cried out: “The writing is disappearing!”

Vanna looked over at once toward the sound. A faint cluster of ghostly green light was reflected in her eyes.

Her breath caught at once.

On the ground, the marks the nun had carved before she died were fading bit by bit, like pencil lines being erased from a page. Wherever a sword mark vanished, tiny sparks of ghostly green flame flickered, so small that the naked eye could barely catch them. No one knew where these “sparks” came from. It was as if they had always been spreading in a dimension

human sight could not reach, and now they had suddenly stepped into the view of people in the Mortal Realm.

Vanna could not have been more familiar with this ghostly green fire.

It was the master of this flame who had guided her to this cathedral!

In that instant, countless guesses surged up in her mind. Some were about the Vanished, some about the ghost captain, and others about Subspace and the number 1885. Yet none of her guesses fit.

No one could explain what role that ghost captain was really playing. Vanna also could not understand why his flame would erase the marks right in front of her at this moment. But one thing was very clear to her—this was no place to stay. She had to get back to the central cathedral at once.

In the blink of an eye, the marks on the ground were gone. The ghostly green flame that had appeared from nowhere also slowly faded from everyone's sight.

"Do not go near this patch of ground. The flames may still be spreading outside the range we can see," Vanna warned her subordinates. "Now pull out of this cathedral. Second squad will stay outside the cathedral, set up a cordon, and wait for orders. Everyone else, return to the central cathedral with me."

The Guardians answered in unison: "Yes!"

Vanna nodded. After a brief thought, she added another order: "Also, notify the reserve forces in the nearby blocks… We are sealing off the entire Sixth District."

In the main hall of the small cathedral, Vanna led the Guardians through.

One Guardian glanced toward the statue of the Goddess without thinking and suddenly cried out: "That praying 'nun' is gone too!"

Chapter 174: Before the Storm

The nun who had been quietly praying in front of the Goddess’s statue was gone.

Only the empty floor remained in front of the pulpit. Bright gas lamps lit the vast main hall and its rows of seats. Vanna and the guardian warriors searched the not?so?large hall from end to end, but they still did not find that strange nun.

Of course, Vanna knew that the nun had most likely “never existed” from the very beginning. The real body had clearly died years ago in the underground sanctum. The figure praying in the main hall was only a projection. But even so, the sudden disappearance of that projection still filled everyone with uneasy confusion.

“Nothing in the corridors and side rooms either!”

The last two guardian warriors who had gone to search also came back to the main hall. Their report confirmed one thing: the nun’s phantom had completely vanished from this cathedral.

Vanna frowned slightly and thought quickly.

The phantom was gone, but when had it disappeared?

Was it when she entered the underground sanctum for the second time? When she saw the real nun’s last numbers written before death? Or…

When that strange, ghostly green flame flared up out of nowhere and wiped away the traces on the floor?

If it was the former, then the phantom might have vanished because she, the “observer from the Mortal Realm”, had seen through the truth and broken part of the illusion here. But if it was the latter… then it meant that the ghost captain had made a move.

That ghost captain had erased the traces in the underground sanctum and, at the same time, wiped away the nun’s phantom in the main hall— for reasons no one knew.

Staying here would not yield anything more. The urgent task was to report what they had found to Bishop Valentine, then go to the archives and confirm the warning she had just sensed.

Vanna quickly led her squad members out of the cathedral. As they crossed the doors and looked back again, they saw, as expected, a cathedral that was completely abandoned and in ruins.

Vanna let out a breath. At least she had brought her subordinates safely out of that strange place. Then, on a sudden impulse, she lifted her head and looked up above the cathedral.

A plump white dove stood on the high spire, tilting its head as it watched them, looking completely harmless.

[Why is this dove still here?]

Vanna could not help feeling a little curious, but she quickly pushed the doubt aside. After arranging personnel to stay and guard the small cathedral, she turned, got into the car, and headed back toward the Central Cathedral.

The white dove spread its wings and flew away from the cathedral at high speed.

But the dove did not go very far. Once it left the line of sight of the guardians posted around the cathedral, it darted straight into a nearby alley.

Ghostly green spirit form fire surged up in the empty alley, twisting into a door and a vortex. Duncan stepped out of the flames, then frowned slightly and looked thoughtfully in the direction of the cathedral.

Bringing this matter into the open had been the right choice. Drawing in Vanna and the official power behind her had produced far more than he expected. The investigation had moved forward. Professionals were professionals; what they knew went far beyond what amateurs like Shirley and Dog could manage.

When he was close enough, Duncan could use the mark he had left on a target to directly listen to what happened around them. Because the mark on Vanna had been strengthened during her last visit to the antique shop, this listening even allowed Duncan to sense, to some extent, the young Inquisitor's emotional shifts. Just now, he and AI had stayed above the cathedral, and through this link he had "watched" the guardian squad's entire investigation inside.

Duncan stood in the shadows of the alley, quietly sorting through the information he had just gained.

It was very likely that the nun had been fighting her own Subspace projection. There had never been other intruders. Had the intruders crawled out through the rift in her own soul?

The clerics of this world… once completely crushed by corruption, would they actually turn into a direct "channel" that linked Subspace and the Mortal Realm?

Did this happen only to clerics, or did all humans carry this hidden risk, with corrupted clerics simply being far more dangerous?

Of all the things he had learned, this was what drew Duncan's attention the most, and what surprised and puzzled him the most.

Duncan did not know much about the True Gods of this world and the Churches under their names. But from what he had observed, he could at least confirm that these Churches stood on the side of order and protection. Their clerics kept the city?states safe in the extraordinary realm, and they were the firmest line of defense against the corruption that seeped from the world’s deep layers.

Yet now he knew that this firm line of defense could, under certain conditions, itself turn into a “pipe” between the Mortal Realm and Subspace… Why?

If this transformation did not happen only to clerics, but could turn any human into a Subspace channel once certain conditions were met, then what would that mean?

The Subspace that everyone feared so much, its ties to the Mortal Realm, to mortal life in the world, seemed far more complex than he had first imagined.

Besides this, there was also the string of numbers “1885” that the nun had left behind.

It was something Duncan and Shirley had not found when they explored this place before, and now it surprised him greatly.

If Vanna’s judgment was right, then the nun had not died in the fragment incident of the Sun in 1889, but had already died in 1885. For the years after that, this small cathedral must have been shrouded in twisted time and space!

What did that mean?

Duncan’s thoughts rose and fell. He slowly lifted his hand and rubbed his fingertips together. A small ghostly green flame quietly burned in front of his eyes.

He could clearly feel the spirit form fire spreading—in invisible dimensions, along the “other side” of the city?state of Pland— and sending faint feedback to him without stop.

This was his third source of confusion.

Shortly after Vanna found the string of numbers in the underground sanctum, the numbers vanished into thin air. spirit form fire had briefly appeared at that moment, so the young Inquisitor would surely think it was the work of “Captain Duncan”. But in fact…

Duncan was even more confused than she was.

He had not erased that string of numbers. He had no idea why the flames he released earlier had suddenly appeared in the underground sanctum and burned away “1885” so precisely. It gave him a feeling that the fire had not spread through space to the cathedral, but had spread through time back to the year 1885.

Duncan suddenly froze.

Maybe… it was not an illusion…

For some reason, he suddenly remembered when he had studied Alice’s wooden box. He remembered the scene he had glimpsed of the Frostholm queen’s execution half a century ago, and the warning he had heard then—

“…Please do not corrupt history…”

Duncan’s face grew dark, his brows slowly knitting together. He thought of something he had heard not long ago:

In this world, everything except Subspace could be corrupted.

…

Vanna hurried back to the Grand Cathedral. She had wanted to go straight to the archives to confirm the severe sense of wrongness in her memory, but she went to see Bishop Valentine first and told the old man what she had found at the small cathedral in the Sixth District.

After listening to Vanna's report, Valentine stayed silent for a long time. He frowned deeply and thought for a while before muttering with a pained expression: "Subspace… this really is the worst kind of trouble among all kinds of trouble…"

"When we were about to leave, the string of numbers pointing to 1885 in the small cathedral and the nun praying in the main hall both disappeared. It seemed related to the power of 'Captain Duncan'," Vanna added. "But we did not stay in the cathedral to run repeated tests. We were worried about the risk of corruption spreading."

"…A wise caution," Bishop Valentine nodded lightly. "We still cannot be sure what attitude that ghost captain really has. For now, it seems that he did give us an important piece of information, but then erased some clues at the end… In any case, he is not our 'friend'."

Vanna thought for a moment and looked at the old man in front of her: "Has there been any reply from Church headquarters? Have you reported our situation to His Eminence the Pope?"

Bishop Valentine looked at Vanna and nodded. "I have reported everything here to the Storm Cathedral. His Eminence the Pope said he will send support as soon as possible— but the Cathedral ship is still some distance from Pland. Even the fastest courier vessel will not reach us in just a few days. So… we must be ready to rely on ourselves."

As he spoke, the old bishop sighed softly, turned around, and gazed at the statue of the Storm Goddess.

“Disaster is brewing, and we do not know when it will break out. Whether Pland, this Sea Jewel, can wipe away the coming gloom will depend on our own ability.”

Chapter 175: Storm Clouds Over the City

At some point the sky had turned gloomy. Thick, heavy clouds like solid masses piled over the city?state. The slightly salty sea wind swept through the streets again and again, as if trying to drive the cold straight into people’s bones.

Old Captain Lawrence stepped out of the cathedral’s front gate and hunched his neck against the cold wind blowing in his face. He looked up at the sky and started to grumble about the terrible weather: “Damn, what rotten luck. I finally finished the observation period, and now I have to walk half an hour home in this wind…”

On the streets around the cathedral square, people walked quickly, as if a downpour could start at any moment. They were thinking about laundry not yet taken in at home or windows left open. The first thing the old captain thought of, however, was his bad?tempered wife. He had been in “quarantine observation” in the cathedral for many days and had not even sent a message. Wouldn’t he get a storm of loving blows, maybe even a bruised nose and swollen face, when he finally went home?

Lawrence rubbed his arms and hands, sighed, and was ready to step into the cold wind. But after only two steps, he saw from the corner of his eye a cathedral guard hurrying toward him. A little further away stood the young therapist in charge of counseling… Heidi, or Hailey, or something like that.

“You’ve got to be kidding…” Lawrence muttered without thinking. The cathedral guard reached him, gave a polite bow, then solemnly held out an arm to block his way. “Sorry, Captain Lawrence. We just received an urgent notice. For now… you still cannot leave.”

“Wasn’t the observation period already over?” Lawrence had already guessed as soon as he saw them, but he still could not help letting his face fall. “You’d better have a good reason.”

“The details are not convenient to tell you, but…” The young church guard also looked a bit troubled, yet he still spoke in an official tone. “It is a direct order from the Inquisitor. The situation has changed. All ordinary people who have had contact with the Vanished must continue to stay in the cathedral.”

Lawrence’s mouth twitched. The moment he heard the words “the Vanished”, he knew he had to obey the order, but his bad mood was something he could not control. The old captain frowned. “Fine, an extension, I get it—but who is going to explain it to my wife? I’ve been gone for…”

“Sorry to interrupt,” before he could finish, Heidi’s voice came from the side. “Do you have some worries?”

Lawrence turned to look at Heidi. During his days of quarantine observation in the cathedral, he had dealt with this young therapist a few times. He knew that although she looked young, she really was a reliable expert, and she had indeed helped him and his crew calm a lot of their tension and anger. So his expression eased a little. “I’ve been away from home too long. My wife is not exactly gentle. I was supposed to be on vacation after my last shipping run. I can’t spend the first half of my time off in quarantine at the cathedral and the second half lying in bed nursing my wounds…”

“…True, no one wants to run into something like this,” Heidi sighed, clearly understanding. She took a glass tube of potion from the medical case she carried and handed it to the old captain. “But things are complicated right now. It’s best to follow the orders from the Grand Cathedral first. Don’t worry, someone will go and contact your family.”

“What is this?” Lawrence took the vial, looked doubtfully at the liquid inside, then looked at Heidi with the same doubt. The therapist’s medical case always seemed to have strange things in it, which made people nervous.

“It calms you down, eases your nerves, and also strengthens your mental defenses a bit,” Heidi said casually. “It’s to get you ready for the next stage of quarantine observation.”

“…Damn it, so there really is no room to bend the rules…” Lawrence felt a stab of pain in his teeth as soon as he heard “next stage of quarantine”. He pulled out the stopper and downed the salty, bitter potion in one gulp, then handed the glass tube back to the therapist.

The potion took effect quickly. The old captain shivered once in the cold wind. His eyes flickered a few times, then calmed down, and he let out a long, complicated sigh.

“Do you need me to walk you back?” Heidi asked in a gentle voice as she watched his expression.

“…No, I know the way,” Lawrence said. His mood was a bit low, but he quickly shook his head with a trace of acceptance. “Sigh, going back to stay there isn’t so bad. At least there’s someone to talk to. Some of those novice monks are actually pretty interesting to chat with…”

He turned in the cold wind and walked alone toward the cathedral’s great doors. Two guardians were already waiting there to escort the old captain

back to the quarantine area.

But just as he was about to pass through the doors, Heidi's voice rang out again. "Mr. Lawrence, as a psychiatrist, I still have to give you some serious advice— it's about time you retired. The Boundless Sea is not good for your mental health."

Lawrence did not answer. He only lifted a hand in a distant wave to show he had heard, then slowly disappeared through the tall, solemn doors.

Only Heidi, with her medical case, and a guardian warrior in a long black coat remained in the square.

There had been a faint respect in the guardian's eyes when he looked at the old captain.

Then the guardian turned his head and looked at the psychiatrist beside him. "Miss Heidi, do you know what's really going on?"

Heidi rolled her eyes. "You're the one from the Church. If even you don't know, how would I, an 'external consultant' sent by City Hall, know anything?"

"But you and Her Excellency the Inquisitor…"

"She hasn't told me anything. In fact, I haven't even seen her since yesterday," Heidi shook her head, then looked curiously at the guardian warrior in front of her. "But I heard she suddenly issued a whole batch of investigation orders? This morning there was even a group of clerical priests who went to City Hall to borrow records…"

"Yeah, a whole pile of investigation tasks," the guardian sighed. "Pulling records, visiting neighborhoods, digging through old cases, and even setting up checkpoints at the Harbor to watch twelve different people who sell fries…"

Heidi: “…?”

“So now even we are guessing what actually happened,” the guardian sighed, raising his head to look at the dark clouds in the sky. “Tch, what awful weather.”

…

Morris sat upright at his desk. His fingers brushed lightly along the rough edge of a heavy tome. His thoughts slowly grew quiet, until he could even hear his own heartbeat.

He lowered his head and slowly opened the Rahm Sacred Tome in front of him. He turned, with practiced ease, to the chapters on mental protection and Discernment of Wisdom, and silently recited the teachings in his heart.

Only after finishing the basic self?suggestion and strengthening of his mind did he stand up. He lit the candles and incense on the nearby table in order, then dripped refined essential oil into three of the flames.

As the flames suddenly flared, he gazed at the mirror in front of the ritual table and looked at his own reflection. A slightly self?mocking smile appeared on his face.

“I really am getting old… Luckily I can still perform the details of these rituals correctly.”

The crackling of the candles slowly grew weaker. The smoke from the incense rose and slowly gathered above the mirror into a cloud that did not disperse. The cloud blocked the old man’s sight so he could no longer clearly see his own reflection. At that point, the protection of his mind and the blessing from Rahm, the God of Wisdom, were complete.

“I have turned away from you for eleven years… yet you are still willing to watch over me,” Morris sighed softly when he saw the ritual finish so smoothly. “Do you still have hopes for me…”

The room stayed quiet. Of course the God of Wisdom would not appear just like that. But Morris still tilted his head as if listening. In that silence he seemed to hear the deity’s instructions. His expression slowly calmed, and he opened a nearby drawer.

A beaded bracelet made from colorful stones lay quietly inside. There were twelve stones in total.

Morris hesitated for a moment, then picked up the bracelet and put it on his wrist.

In that instant he felt a rush of clarity in his head, as if a Veil that had covered him for many years had suddenly lifted. He glanced once more at the layer of smoke still hanging in front of the mirror, then finally made up his mind and pushed the door open to leave the room.

Heidi was not at home, and the big, empty house felt especially quiet.

The bedroom he shared with his wife was not far away on the left. The door was half open, the inside dim and silent.

Morris touched the rune bead bracelet on his wrist. He did not dare look toward the half?open door. Instead, he almost fled, walking quickly down the corridor, through the living room, and out the front door. He started the car parked in the yard and drove toward the Lower City.

At the same time, a white dove skimmed quickly over the low, old buildings of the Lower City.

Where no one was watching, the white dove flew through a second?floor window of Duncan’s antique shop. A moment later, a flicker of ghostly green light flashed behind the glass.

Duncan stepped out of the flames. He glanced at the bad weather outside, then at the clock hanging on the wall not far away— there was still a little time before Nina came home from school.

He went down to the first floor, opened the shop door, and carried out a chair. He sat in the doorway, his face calm, and quietly watched the street in front of him, lost in thought.

Chapter 176: A Warm Family

Nina appeared in Duncan's sight. The girl ran all the way toward him, a happy smile on her face. When she saw her uncle sitting in a daze by the door of the antique shop, she sped up and raised her hand to wave: "Uncle, I'm back!"

Duncan snapped out of his thoughts. He put his worries aside for the moment and stood up to greet his "niece". When he saw the girl out of breath, he paused, frowned a little, and said: "Didn't I give you money for the ride? Why did you still run back after school?"

Nina stopped in front of Duncan and took a few deep breaths. She scratched her hair in embarrassment, then reached into the schoolbag in her hand and started rummaging around. After a long while, she finally pulled out a small paper packet and handed it over: "I… passed by Doctor Albert's clinic on the way back…"

Duncan took the packet and pinched it lightly. He realized there were several pills inside.

"Doctor Albert said you've been using alcohol to dull the pain for a long time," Nina explained in a small voice, "and even though your health is better now and you've successfully quit drinking, people who drank for a long time can easily have bad reactions when they suddenly stop. This is medicine to ease alcohol withdrawal. If you start feeling unwell, you can take one…

“Also, Doctor Albert said that as long as your health hasn’t worsened recently, you can stop taking the medicine you used before. But he still suggests that, if you have time, you should go to his clinic for a full check-up…”

Duncan quietly listened to Nina’s soft, even slightly cautious explanation. He did not speak for a long time. Only after she finished did he silently tuck the little packet of pills carefully into an inner pocket close to his body.

Then he reached out and placed his hand on Nina’s hair, gently rubbing it.

“Uncle?” Nina looked up at him in confusion. She saw a hard-to-describe seriousness on Duncan’s face, and in that seriousness there was even a hint of worry. Her sensitive heart suddenly became uneasy: “What… what’s wrong? Are you feeling sick? Or…”

“I’m fine.” Duncan suddenly smiled. He bent down a little, his gaze meeting Nina’s eyes, and said: “But from now on, don’t use your fare money to buy medicine for me. Our family doesn’t lack money anymore. You can also bring more pocket money with you… if it’s not enough, just ask me.”

Nina stared blankly at Duncan. She felt that her uncle suddenly seemed a little strange, but she could not say exactly what was wrong. She stared for a long time before she finally nodded hesitantly: “Oh… oh…”

Then she thought of something. She craned her neck to look into the shop, and an expression that was both expectant and hesitant appeared on her face: “Uncle, um… you said that when I came back from school, you’d teach me to ride the bicycle…”

“The weather isn’t very good right now.” Duncan raised his eyebrows. “It might rain.”

“We’ll just stay by the door,” Nina said in a small, hopeful voice as she grabbed Duncan’s arm. “If it rains, we can go back inside right away…”

Duncan laughed and nodded helplessly: “Alright. Put your schoolbag away first. I’ll teach you to ride the bicycle. But we can only practice for a little while. I still haven’t cooked dinner.”

“Okay!”

Nina let out a small cheer, then dashed into the antique shop like a charging soldier. She tossed her schoolbag onto the counter and pushed out the brand-new bicycle. Her pushing posture was crooked. She wrestled with the doorframe for quite a while before she finally managed to get the bike in front of Duncan.

“…Honestly, I feel like you even need to learn how to push the bike from scratch,” Duncan said. He looked at Nina’s clumsy movements and could not help sighing with a half-laugh, half-cry expression. Then he walked up and steadied the handlebars. “But seeing how excited you are, just get on first. I’ll hold the bike for you. You just try pedaling and get used to keeping your balance while it’s moving.”

Nina nodded obediently. Once Duncan had the bike steady, she grabbed the handlebars, stepped on the pedal, and climbed up onto the seat. As she struggled her way up, she kept repeating: “Uncle, you have to hold it tight! Don’t you dare let go!”

“Alright, alright, just trust me…”

The slightly salty, cold wind blew over the old streets of the Lower City, whipping up fallen leaves and dust between the low, rundown buildings. Dark clouds hung very low, yet the rain that might fall at any time still seemed to hesitate in the sky, refusing to drop to the ground.

On the small patch of open ground in front of the antique shop, a girl's excited yet nervous cries rang out, mixed with the bike bell's random jingling and, every now and then, Duncan's instructions and teasing.

A pure black, old-fashioned private car stopped in the open space near the antique shop. An old man wearing an old-style woolen scholar's coat, carrying a Gatekeeper's cane, and wearing a short top hat pushed open the car door and looked toward the antique shop.

Morris saw that familiar, old shop, and he also saw the uncle and niece who were practicing riding the bicycle on the open space in front of it.

It was an ordinary Lower City street scene, a warm and simple bit of family life. Everything looked so normal. Even under the low-hanging clouds and the chill of the autumn wind, the scene in the distance still looked especially warm and peaceful.

However, Heidi had spent only half a day in that antique shop and had already burned through one of the God of Wisdom Rahm's blessings—and that was with a Deep Sea Inquisitor guarding her.

Yet afterward, neither Heidi herself nor Inquisitor Vanna had noticed even the slightest anomaly.

Morris took a quiet breath. Even as he looked at such an everyday scene, his heart started beating faster.

He clenched his teeth. Instead of calling out to the uncle and niece in front of the antique shop, he decided to finish his observation of the shop first. If possible, he truly did not want to drag unrelated people into an supernatural incident.

The old man searched in the pocket of his coat and took out a blessed monocle with a thin pale-gold chain. One end of the fine chain was clipped to the inside of his pocket, and the other end was attached to the frame. On

the frame, Rahm’s name and many holy symbols were carved in ancient Critt letters. In the clear lens, faint light flowed.

“May wisdom grant me keen eyes, enlighten my mind, let me see the truth, and pierce the fog…”

Morris murmured a short benediction, then clipped the blessed monocle into his eye socket. He turned his face toward the antique shop and “opened” the eye he had chosen to seal eleven years ago…

Morris felt dazed for a moment. He lowered his head and looked at the blessed monocle in his hand. He saw Rahm’s name and the holy symbols carved on the frame. Faint light stirred in the clear lens.

“May wisdom grant me keen eyes…”

He whispered the benediction again and clipped the blessed monocle into his eye socket, then raised his head…

Morris felt dazed again. He lowered his head and looked at the blessed monocle in his hand.

A cold wind suddenly blew from the other side of the street, carrying a low murmur. The old scholar stopped the motion he was about to make, then suddenly raised his right wrist.

A bracelet woven from colorful stones and silk thread circled his wrist. There were eight stones in total.

The cold wind blew by, dragging fallen leaves and the chill of late autumn with it. The sounds in Morris’s ears seemed to fade away. The noise of traffic in the street and the bells from the Cathedral in the distance became so faint that they might have been coming from another world. He heard only the pounding of his own heart. The roar of his blood filled his ears like thunder. Amid that heartbeat, only the sounds from one direction stayed clear—

A girl’s happy yet nervous voice: “Uncle, hold it steady! Ah, it’s tilting, it’s tilting… the bike is going to fall!”

A middle-aged man’s warm voice, carrying a smile: “I’m holding it. It won’t fall. If you keep the handlebars straight, it won’t tilt… Pedal forward and keep going. That’s how a bicycle works. As long as you pedal and hold the handlebars, it won’t fall over.”

“You really have to hold it! I’m going forward!”

“Go on. I’m right behind you.”

Morris suddenly heard another sound, a creaking noise like grinding bones. As it came, his field of vision shifted and turned a little. He needed a second to understand what was happening.

He was slowly turning his neck, moving his gaze from the antique shop to the patch of open ground by its door.

A strong warning surged up from his soul. The bracelet on his wrist, which still held eight stones, let out a low, sobbing sound. Each stone became burning hot, like they were trying to drag a drowning person out of the water by force, pulling at his reason in vain. Morris could still think. He knew the divine blessings he had placed on himself before leaving home had been activated and were working. But he could only do this basic thinking—his neck kept turning, and his eyes, out of his control, were looking toward the most dangerous place.

[Close your eyes! Close your eyes! Close your eyes!]

Countless voices exploded in his mind, but his reason could not drive his muscles to finish even this simplest action. He turned his head, inch by inch, and finally, with both his eyes “opened” by the divine blessing, he saw the source of the voices.

He saw a frenzied, writhing vortex of light and shadow, and a mirror that seemed to reflect all times and all spaces at once, shattered into countless fragments. These things were mixed together, tangled into a barely human-shaped giant whose surface was covered in starlight. The giant bent down a little and carefully supported…

Supported a spraying arc of blazing flame.

A thunderous blast went off in Morris’s mind, and then the whole world fell quiet.

Chapter 177: madness threshold

After a thunderous bang, the whole world fell quiet.

Morris felt his consciousness drifting, as if it had completely left his body. He did not know where he was. He did not know what year it was. For a moment—or maybe for a long stretch of time—he even forgot his own name. He simply floated in a mindless state in a field of chaotic nothingness, surrounded by streams of light and shadow beyond human understanding and by deathly silence.

Morris spent a very, very long time piecing his shattered thoughts back together, slowly repairing a broken and incomplete sense of self—

He remembered that his name was Morris. He lived in the city-state of Pland. He was a history scholar. Today, he had planned to visit an antique shop in the Lower City to find out what had almost taken his daughter’s life.

He had found out.

It was a warm little Subspace family.

Countless roars and shrill noises like the splitting of the earth finally exploded. In that empty and silent chaos, something appeared again that he could sense. The humanity he had just pieced together almost got shattered again by this noise, but just before he was completely wiped out, he “saw” a layer of hazy fog gather from all directions and wrap around all his senses.

This “fog” protected his mind. Under a protection called the Veil of Ignorance, it cut him off from the noise and the chaotic streams of light and shadow. Morris could think again. Through the fog, he looked into the surroundings and found that he could no longer see those truths and pieces of knowledge that drove people insane. In the endless depths of the mist, only one cluster of flickering light caught his attention.

It was a dim glow formed by many light sources of different sizes. In the center was a red light, roughly the size of a human head. Around it spun dozens of tiny blue, green, and red points of light. They flashed quickly like some kind of matrix, seemingly without any pattern, yet as if they held a certain… “sanity”.

In the middle of countless chaotic light streams, these regularly flickering lights became the anchor that finally steadied Morris’s mind. After his first shock, he quickly realized what those little lights were—

He had faced God of Wisdom Rahm directly.

In every university and laboratory of Truth Academy, there was an image of Rahm. The Rahm Sacred Tome also had matching passages. This deity who held the divine authority of both wisdom and stupidity did not have a human shape. Rahm hid in the fog for long ages. When the silhouette appeared from time to time, it took the form of a flat surface covered in tiny lights, with dozens of points of light circling a round glow.

“My Lord!” Morris shivered and quickly bowed toward the luminous matrix that was sheltering him. “Are you here to guide me?”

Those flickering “lights” did not answer the old scholar. He only felt a deep, muffled vibration. After quite a long time, Rahm’s “voice” finally reached Morris from deep inside his mind—

“Return, contact, understand, transmit…”

“You…”

Morris stared in disbelief at that mass of light. He could not understand Rahm’s will. But this elusive God of Wisdom did not give him the chance to ask anything more. In the next second, a powerful sense of rejection surged up. In an instant, Morris was “pushed” out of that chaotic and terrifying place.

His body swayed. His brain felt as if it were boiling. Information from the mortal world flooded his senses again—the noise of traffic on the street, the distant ringing of bells, the cold wind, and the clear ringing of a bicycle bell.

Then came the sound of quick footsteps and a girl’s worried voice. The voice was very familiar. It was his student.

“Mr. Morris?! Why are you here… Are you alright?”

In a daze, Morris lifted his head and saw Nina standing in front of him. But in the very next second, the girl in front of his eyes turned into a burning arc of flame, with ashes swirling around her that seemed able to cover the whole city-state—then she turned back into human form.

His stiff gaze shifted sideways. He saw a giant covered in starlight looking down at him. Inside the giant’s body flowed maddening streams of light and shadow. Then the giant suddenly became a kind-faced middle-aged man. The man looked at him with concern, his eyes full of the Shadows of Subspace.

The distant street trembled as well. The ground under his feet twisted and writhed. The doors and windows of the shop were sometimes normal and sometimes turned into hollow black holes. The sky hung down at a crooked angle. Rivers of flame and shapeless limbs flickered between the clouds. A

passerby on a bicycle rushed past. His body suddenly turned into cracked concrete, then returned to normal in the next second.

Morris lowered his head with great effort and looked at his own wrist.

He was wearing a bracelet woven from colorful stones and thread. Only four stones remained.

But the stones did not keep breaking, and his mind did not keep sliding further into madness. The world in his eyes was still badly twisted, but his ability to think and judge had come back—at least partly.

The old scholar quickly judged his current condition. Under Rahm's protection, he had entered a briefly balanced madness threshold state.

He had gone mad—but the god had made his madness look like sanity.

He might still recover, but he had to find a way to save himself before Rahm's protection ended and all the stones broke. Otherwise, this temporary madness threshold might collapse at any time. When that happened, no one would be able to pull his reason back from the chaos.

While Morris's thoughts crawled along slowly in his mind, Nina and Duncan were also watching the clearly abnormal old man with worried eyes.

They had been practicing with the bicycle when they suddenly saw Morris standing on the empty patch of ground to the side. At first, Nina wanted to run over and greet him, but halfway there she noticed something wrong with the expression on the old man's face.

His eyes were dull and empty. His mind seemed absent. He did not respond to anything around him, like someone standing there asleep with his eyes open.

“Could he have suddenly gone senile?” Duncan muttered. He waved a hand in front of Morris’s face, then turned his head to look at Nina. “Has your teacher been spacing out like this at school these past two days?”

“No,” Nina said, shaking her head. She stepped forward and held the old man’s arm as she spoke: “Teacher has always been very healthy. How could he suddenly get senile?”

“You never know with people his age,” Duncan said as he took Morris’s other arm. He looked up at the sky. “Don’t talk out here. It’s about to rain. Let’s get the old gentleman inside first.”

Nina answered softly and helped Duncan support the dazed Morris into the shop. Then she jogged back to the open ground outside and pushed the bicycle indoors.

Duncan helped Morris sit down on a chair beside the counter. The old man seemed to have regained a bit of thinking ability by then. He sat down stiffly, his head slowly turning from side to side, and at last his gaze settled on Duncan.

“Return, contact, understand, transmit…”

Rahm’s voice suddenly echoed in his mind.

The small bit of reason still left in Morris seemed to understand these four words a little.

Was this the will of the God of Wisdom? Did Rahm want him to keep interacting with the “being” in front of him?

For the moment, Duncan’s image in Morris’s eyes stabilized into human form again. The scene around him was still trembling and writhing, but at least he could no longer see the starry giant’s true body. That allowed his reason to gain a slight upper hand.

Morris had already realized that this man, who looked like an ordinary antique shop owner, was absolutely not a being that should exist in the Mortal Realm.

Even his “student”, that girl who always smiled gently and stayed sunny and optimistic, was not a normal human.

If he stayed here and kept talking with this “family”, he might soon pass the balance point of the madness threshold and fall from temporary madness into the abyss of permanent madness.

But the God of Wisdom’s voice seemed to have taken root in his mind, making him sit there against his will. At the same time, another, even bolder thought slowly rose up from the bottom of his heart.

In this god-protected madness threshold state, no matter how close his mind drifted toward chaos, it would not completely fall into a runaway state. As long as he did not cross that critical point, he could even face Subspace directly during this brief balance and still keep his self, still keep his humanity…

It was said that in the Critt Kingdom, the greatest and most insane knowledge pursuers would even use this on purpose. After a lifetime of preparation, they would take potions and perform a ritual to actively embrace the madness threshold. In their one and only chance, they would gaze into the truth of Subspace and bring precious knowledge back to the Mortal Realm, then go to their deaths without regret.

Now, he seemed to be standing on the same “battlefield” where those sages of Critt had once stood.

Slowly, the old gentleman’s blank, stiff face changed. A smile appeared. His cloudy eyes looked at Duncan, and he spoke slowly: “Hello, Mr. Duncan.”

Watching the change in the old man’s expression, Duncan suddenly felt a chill.

This old gentleman… why did his smile suddenly look so scary?

Chapter 178: Friendly

Duncan carefully watched the old man's expression. The strange feeling from just now had not faded. He could clearly see that Morris was not in a normal state, but unfortunately, he was no doctor.

"Do you need me to find a doctor?" he asked with concern. "How do you feel now? Do you have any dizziness or nausea? Or are you feeling dazed?"

Morris rubbed his forehead.

In his ears, Duncan's voice seemed mixed with ten thousand overlapping howls of noise. At the same time as the sound waves entered his ears, dazzling, multicolored "colors" also rushed straight at him. These "messages" felt crammed with knowledge no humans could understand, testing his mind every single second. Yet even in a madness threshold state, he still barely held on to his sanity and slowly shook his head: "I'm fine. I just need to rest for a bit…"

The "existence" in front of him, whose true form he did not know, was showing concern for him. But now, Morris did not dare even imagine what kind of "reality" lay behind that appearance of concern. Perhaps it was a thousand pairs of eyes staring at him. Or perhaps dense, writhing teeth and tongues. Were those caring words a whisper from Subspace, or a roar from the Abyssal Deep, from the Deep Sea?

He thanked Rahm for granting him this moment of dullness. He did not have to pay too much attention to that truth.

He only tried to respond as a "person", as normally as he could.

At the same time, he also tried to see whether he could actively shut the Eye of Truth he had opened when he got off the carriage. This God-given ability was what the followers of the God of Wisdom relied on when they explored the world. Yet now… its price truly deserved its place as the most dangerous divine blessing of the Four Gods.

He failed. The Eye of Truth was already open and could not be closed in a short time. And even if he closed it, what use would it be? A mind that had fallen into the madness threshold would not automatically recover just because he shut his eyes…

Morris thought in a daze. After a while, he slowly spoke: “I… just came to visit, to express my thanks… oh, yes, my thanks, on behalf of my daughter. Once again, thank you for your help at the City Museum last time. She asked me…”

He suddenly stalled, hesitated for several seconds, then picked up the thread of his thoughts: “She asked me to bring a letter. It’s in my pocket.”

The old man groped around and took a carefully sealed envelope from his coat pocket, then handed it to Duncan. Duncan took it and opened it on the spot. Apart from some greetings at the beginning, it contained a report on Nina’s physical and mental health and the doctor’s recommendations.

This was what Heidi had written after giving Nina hypnosis treatment last time. She had indeed said she would write a proper letter and send it over, and Duncan still remembered that.

“No need to be so polite. In that situation, stepping in to save her was only my instinctive reaction,” Duncan put the letter away and said to Morris with a serious face. “Also, thank Miss Heidi for me—since the hypnosis session last time, Nina has been much better and hasn’t had that strange dream these days.”

Morris nodded and pressed his fingers to the Sun acupoint at his temple. As he organized his words, he mentally reminded himself not to stare into Duncan's eyes: "Have you… been well these days?"

"Me? I'm fine," Duncan felt a bit baffled. He thought the old Mister's way of starting a conversation today was strange. "I'm in good health, full of energy, and in a good mood—other than today's terrible weather being a little depressing, there's nothing wrong."

The weather?

[Such a small change in the weather could make an Eldritch God feel "depressed"—was that the latest joke going around in Subspace?]

Morris felt his head was slightly better than before. After hearing Duncan's words, he even had the mood to mutter inwardly. At the same time, he heard Nina's voice coming from not far away: "Uncle! I put the bicycle away and closed the shop door! The wind outside is getting stronger and stronger… How is Mr. Morris?"

"He's much better, but he still hasn't told me what was wrong just now," Duncan turned back to look at Nina as she walked toward them. "Why don't you stay with the old Mr. later, and I'll send Miss Heidi an express dispatch or a telegram and ask her to come pick him up…"

"No, no, no, I'm fine," before Duncan finished, Morris suddenly raised his voice and waved his hands repeatedly. "There is no need to ask her to come. It's just an old problem. Resting for a while will be enough."

Duncan was startled by the old Mister's sudden intensity. He looked Morris up and down twice. After confirming the man's condition and attitude, he nodded: "All right, then I won't go. Nina, go upstairs and make some soup. A hot meal might make Mr. Morris feel a bit better."

Nina blinked and glanced in confusion between Duncan and her teacher. For some reason she felt the atmosphere here was a little strange, but she quickly nodded obediently: “Oh!”

The girl ran lightly up the stairs, and the thump-thump-thump of her footsteps gradually faded.

After Nina left, Morris also felt his mental pressure lessen a little again. Compared to the massive pressure Duncan brought, this bit of relief was almost negligible, but he still let out a quiet breath.

Then the old man who dealt with history all day fell silent for a moment, and only then carefully chose his words and spoke: “Was my behavior just now very out of line?”

Duncan’s eyes had been fixed on Morris’s changes the whole time. At first he only felt that the other man’s words and actions were unusually strange today. But slowly, he seemed to see a trace of a familiar… “feeling” in the old man’s reactions. As he tried to recall where that familiarity came from, he casually replied: “It was a little strange. So what exactly is going on?”

Morris was silent for two or three seconds before he spoke in a low, cautious voice: “In my line of work, constantly dealing with history and knowledge, the mind can sometimes be a bit sensitive.”

He only wanted to probe a little, to see what attitude this “Subspace existence” in front of him truly had, this being who always behaved kindly on the surface and had never caused any trouble while living here.

When Duncan heard that seemingly meaningful line, he immediately frowned. All of a sudden, he knew what that familiar feeling was!

Morris’s strange reaction had appeared on another acquaintance as well… on Dog!

The Abyssal Hound at Shirley's side, the Abyssal demon that possessed a special "true vision"! Dog had also been this terrified and nervous when he saw him—because the dog could see some of the "true situation" beneath this human body. The difference was, Dog was a Abyssal demon with an extremely high resistance to corruption, while Morris was a fragile human. So Morris's reaction would be even stronger. In other words…

Duncan vaguely guessed the truth and immediately raised his head to look into Morris's eyes: "You saw something you shouldn't have, didn't you?"

Morris drew in a cold breath.

But in the next second, the doomsday he had expected did not descend. On the contrary, he again felt the mental pressure on him rapidly lessen, even shrinking to a level that, even without Rahm's blessing, he could barely endure as a human!

Silently, Duncan shifted his "main consciousness" back to the Vanished, and only used the "remote control" skill of walking the Spirit Realm to control the body in the antique shop.

After this period of "practice", he could now direct his distant body normally even while controlling it remotely, and could sense the environment around that body. The only effect was that the power he could draw on would be weaker—but there were no enemies here anyway.

He wanted to see whether this would make Morris feel a little better.

"Feeling better now?"

Duncan's deep, gentle voice sounded beside him, jolting Morris back to awareness.

The old man hurriedly lifted his head. He saw Duncan's solid, clear, harmless human form. Out of the corner of his eye, he noticed that the surrounding environment had stabilized.

The chaotic lights and shadows had vanished. The noise was gradually dying away. The torn buildings, the flowing flames, and the crawling, twisted dark things all disappeared from his sight. His mind was rapidly recovering, and the dangerous madness threshold state even showed signs of improvement.

He looked at Duncan in disbelief. Duncan gave him an apologetic nod: “Sorry. I really didn’t expect a human to have such ‘good eyes’. In the past I only ever scared a Abyssal demon, and a Abyssal demon’s nerves are much tougher than a human’s.”

“I… I’m much better,” Morris swallowed. The process of his mind gradually recovering was actually uncomfortable too. He could feel his heart pounding as if it were about to burst. But at least this let him regain most of his ability to think—and let him analyze useful information from Duncan’s words. “I… ah, I never thought I would see your true form. I was too careless. These years of living away from my faith have made me lax…”

Duncan did not pay attention to Morris’s muttering at the end.

He was thinking quickly, wondering how he should wrap up the situation in front of him.

After all, this great Historian was not Dog. The latter could be dealt with by scaring him a bit, but the old Mr. could not be handled with such crude methods.

“I’m very curious,” he said suddenly in the middle of his thoughts. “Why can you see?”

“I…” Morris opened his mouth and, after a slight hesitation, chose to be honest. “I am a follower of the God of Wisdom Rahm.”

Chapter 179: Have Some Self-Awareness

Duncan recalled what he had read in books.

The God of Wisdom Rahm, one of the Four Gods who sheltered the world in the Deep Sea era. Like the Storm Goddess and the Lord of Death, this deity also wielded two mutually conflicting Divine Authorities—He was the Giver of Wisdom, and also bore the holy title “God of Folly” or “Gospel of Foolishness”.

There were not many believers who followed this deity. They usually needed to pass very harsh examinations to gain the right to convert. But once they successfully devoted themselves to this deity, the believers would receive two kinds of blessings at the same time.

The first was wisdom. It could let mortals perceive the truth, grasp knowledge, more easily understand the workings of all things, and sense truths that might interfere with their own fate.

The second was dullness. It could raise a barrier called “ignorance”, keeping one away from truths that came too early, and away from the corruption and temptation of Subspace—in this world ringed with danger, the dull were truly blessed.

It was obvious what meaning these two blessings from Rahm had in the Deep Sea era, a time full of Anomalies and Visions, when madness reigned beneath the Deep Sea and clouds shrouded the surface. The believers of the God of Wisdom might be few, but each one was the elite of civilization.

From upstairs came the sounds of Nina busy in the kitchen. Outside the door, the noise of carriages and horses in the street was growing sparse. Amid these everyday sounds, the first floor of the antique shop felt especially quiet and comfortable.

Duncan sat behind the counter, his fingers interlaced on the countertop, and looked thoughtfully at old Mr. Morris.

The God of Wisdom's blessing was a very good thing. But clearly, because of their professional habits and instinctive pursuit of knowledge, His believers faced even greater dangers in their daily lives.

Not even a god could withstand the output of such a total-party-kill engine —if this old gentleman of history were placed in some other story, the tentacles growing from his body by now would probably already be a foot long.

By now, Duncan already understood what was going on. He had some sense of his own uniqueness, but he was more curious at the moment: "Can all believers of the God of Wisdom see through me the way you do?"

"I'm afraid only the most outstanding ones, those most favored by the God of Wisdom, can…" Morris rubbed his head. To him, Duncan's voice was still mixed with some sharp noise, but at least most of it now was sound a human could understand. "You might find this a bit ironic… but most of Rahm's believers actually don't even have the… qualification to have their minds taken by you."

"Oh, so you are especially blessed," Duncan muttered with a somewhat odd expression, especially when he said the words "divine blessing". No matter how he thought about it, it sounded awkward. "The 'divine blessings' in this place of yours are really fatal… Wait, then why were you fine the last time you came?"

Morris was a bit surprised. He did not know whether Duncan truly did not know, or was maliciously playing the part of an ignorant mortal. But in the current situation, he did not dare let his thoughts wander. He could only force himself to rein them in while he answered: “Even Rahm believers who bear a divine blessing do not keep the Eye of Truth open at all times. The last time I came, I did not use any divine gift, but this time…”

The old gent gave a bitter smile and raised his hand to point at his own eye. The blessed monocle he had used earlier to enhance the ritual’s effect had already been removed, yet one of his eyeballs still glowed faintly with a whitish light. Between the sclera and the pupil, a ring of floating radiance could still be seen, easy to distinguish if one came closer.

Duncan was very curious: “…So you can’t end this effect now?”

“…I tried. It didn’t work,” Morris shook his head. “And even if I did manage to end it, it wouldn’t mean much. I have already seen… your appearance.”

“…I’m very sorry. I didn’t actually mean to,” Duncan felt rather guilty. “Will you be able to recover after you go back? Or will you need some special form of treatment?”

“I…” Morris opened his mouth, feeling extremely strange inside. In his earlier years he had imagined whether constantly studying history would lead him to form a connection with some eerie and dangerous existence. He had imagined what terrifying scene it would be to one day stand face to face with some being from the Abyssal Deep, from the Deep Sea, or from Subspace. But he had never thought the situation would look like this—

He really had met a maddening Subspace Shadow. This “Shadow” was very polite, even asking after his health and showing concern for a human who had been frightened half to death by “Him”.

But a being from Subspace… was His “concern” really the kind of “concern” a human could understand?

“I’m fine,” the old Mr. finally shook his head. “I’m already much better now. After you drew back your… presence, I think I should be all right.”

“That’s good then. It seems I will have to be more careful when I move around in the city-state in the future—there are still humans with eyes as sharp as yours among you. That’s a troublesome matter,” Duncan nodded, then asked curiously, “In that case, you didn’t just come to ‘take a look’ today, did you? Why did you open your Eye of Truth outside the antique shop? What were you looking for?”

Morris’s heart gave a heavy thump.

He met Duncan’s gaze and saw only an ordinary middle-aged face with a bit of curiosity and concern on it. Yet around that face, between the shelves behind him, those quivering, twisted things began to surface bit by bit again.

Only when the other’s voice suddenly rang out again did the distortions in Morris’s sight return to normal once more.

“You are hesitating. You have concerns. You don’t want to answer this question,” Duncan read the old Mister’s emotions from his eyes, and at the same time a vague answer surfaced in his heart. “Does it have to do with Miss Heidi?”

“How did you know…”

“Miss Heidi is a psychiatrist, and she also seems to be a believer of Rahm—though she doesn’t look as ‘senior’ as you,” Duncan answered calmly. “Now that I think about it, she seemed a bit strange when she left with Miss Vanna last time… If I then consider how you reacted to my question just now, it’s not hard to connect the dots.”

“…It is indeed as you say,” Morris sighed, knowing he could no longer hide it. “After Heidi went back, I discovered that a layer of the mind ward on her had been pierced. But at the time I only thought there was some dangerous object in this antique shop. I never imagined…”

He sighed again and looked at Duncan opposite him.

Duncan had already furrowed his brow.

[Heidi… That young psychiatrist had only given Nina a hypnosis session in the antique shop, and a layer of her mind ward had already been pierced?]

He had known nothing about this—Heidi herself seemed not to have noticed at the time either!

Morris looked uneasily at the middle-aged man across the counter. He saw that the other seemed lost in thought and did not dare to ask anything rashly. Taking advantage of this short silence, he worked hard to control his thoughts and repair his damaged mind, while at the same time sneaking a glance at the rune bead bracelet on his wrist.

There were still four colored beads left.

Rahm’s blessing was calm.

He finally let out a slight breath of relief. At that moment, Duncan also finally lifted his head from his thoughts.

“She probably doesn’t know anything about this, does she?”

“Yes, Heidi doesn’t know anything,” Morris answered at once. Only when it came to matters related to his daughter was his mind as clear as usual. “She didn’t even notice that her blessing had been damaged, and she certainly doesn’t know that I came here today…”

“Then I won’t disturb her. I’ll only offer my apologies to you,” Duncan said with great courtesy. “Let this cancel out the assistance I gave at the City

Museum back then."

He paused there, then thought of another question that made him very curious: "Then could you describe it to me in detail? Describe the scene you just saw—if it's not too much trouble."

For a moment, Morris did not react. Seeing this, Duncan explained: "I'm very curious what I look like in the eyes of different 'observers'—a mirror can't solve that problem."

Duncan truly was curious about this. Understanding his "true form" in different people's eyes might help him grasp his special powers and uncover the secrets of this body as soon as possible.

Morris hesitated. In his mind he again saw that inhuman horror he'd seen at the door of the antique shop just now, and even felt his hard-won calmness starting to shake. But under Duncan's unblinking gaze, he finally swallowed and slowly spoke in a low voice:

"I… saw you as a giant filled with chaotic streams of light, your body draped in starlight, standing on a twisted, grotesque street. You were holding Nina—she was an arc-shaped stream of flame, erupting violently…"

At first, as he listened to the first half, Duncan only nodded slowly, thinking that this image did live up to his reputation on the Boundless Sea. But when he heard the second half, his eyes instantly widened and he almost choked on his own saliva: "Cough… cough, cough… What did you say? What is Nina in your eyes?!"

Morris jumped in fright but had no time to think it through: "A… an arc-shaped stream of flame, erupting violently… Is there some problem with that?"

Duncan: "…"

Chapter 180: The History Scholar Talks of History

What was wrong? A lot was wrong.

Duncan stared wide-eyed at the old gentleman in front of him. Very soon he realized that Morris had no idea what the jet of flame he had seen in Duncan's eyes really meant. This scholar knew nothing about the fragments of the Sun. He had most likely taken Nina for another "supernatural being", like Duncan's retainer, or some other thing that had slipped out of Subspace.

That was indeed what Morris thought. The moment he saw that erupting flame, he had taken his "student" as a being similar to Duncan. As for why this "Subspace family" had one who looked like a giant and another who looked like a mass of fire, he did not think about it at all. When it came to Subspace, strange was normal. There were no living people in that place anyway, and the big bosses there could grow in whatever shape they liked…

However, seeing Duncan's reaction now, Morris faintly realized that things might not be as he had guessed.

"Nina, she…" The old man spoke hesitantly. After the terror and shock from before, he now felt a new emotion rising in him—worry for his own student.

Even he felt this worry was a little ridiculous, because that jet of flame—no matter what its true body was—was clearly powerful to a staggering degree.

A being that strong could not possibly still be his frail and ordinary student.

Duncan shook his head.

“Nina is not the same as me—she is an ordinary person, and she always has been,” he said slowly, his expression very serious. “She herself does not know that there is anything special about her. As for the flame you mentioned… that may be ‘something else’.”

“I… do not quite understand.”

Duncan looked at Morris for a long moment. In the end, he still did not bring up the matter of the Sun fragment directly. Instead, he suddenly changed the subject: “Do you know much about the so?called ‘true Sun god’ worshiped by the Suntists?”

“The true Sun god?” Morris frowned. He did not know why Duncan had suddenly steered the talk here, but he still answered quickly: “Of course I know a bit. After all, those cultists have existed for a very long time, and many of their ritual acts of worship are part of historical research.

“‘True Sun god’ is what they call their own deity. But believers of the True Gods usually do not say it that way. We call It the Black Sun, or the Black Sun god. In some very old texts, ancient scholars even called It the ‘Creeping Sun Wheel’.”

“Creeping Sun Wheel?” Duncan raised his eyebrows. He had heard the name Black Sun before, but this title “Creeping Sun Wheel” was new to him. The name at once brought back the vision he had seen through the Sun mask he had used as a medium—the rotting limbs under a glorious corona, the eerie Eldritch Gods burning fiercely.

“Yes. Outside of specialist circles, very few people mention that name, because it comes from records passed down from the Ancient Kingdom Era. The earliest manuscript was written in the Critt script. That makes the title

‘Creeping Sun Wheel’ carry a certain mystical pull, and spreading it too widely among ordinary people might have bad effects.”

Morris nodded as he explained these details. While he talked about academic matters, he seemed to forget the terrifying “reality” behind Duncan. He slipped back into the mood from days ago, when he had visited this antique shop and chatted happily with the shopkeeper.

He even felt that the buzzing noise in his head had faded away without him noticing.

“The Critt Ancient Kingdom…” Duncan was quite surprised. “Those cultists who worship the Sun god have such a long history?!”

“…Yes. As unbelievable as it sounds, those heretics who worship the Creeping Sun Wheel can even be traced back to the High Age of the Ancient Kingdom. And if we remember that Vision 001?the Sun only rose from the sea after the Critt Ancient Kingdom collapsed…” Morris paused here. He seemed to struggle with himself for a few seconds before going on. “In truth, orthodox academia and the Four Gods Church have never been willing to face this question head on. If we look at the era when the Sun Vision rose, the faith in the Black Sun is actually older than the history of Vision 001.”

For a while, Duncan said nothing.

The history of the Black Sun being older than the history of the Sun Vision was a very reasonable fact, yet it was one that the Four Gods Church was not eager to admit.

Because admitting this fact meant admitting something else at the same time—that one claim made by the Sun believers was true:

The “true Sun god” had been the real Sun in the Age of Antiquity, and the later?rising Sun Vision was in fact only a “profane construct” that had

stolen the Sun's divine authority.

"…So those Suntists were right. Before the age of the Deep Sea, it was their 'Lord' who shone on this world," Duncan finally said after half a minute of silence. "If the standard is 'the older, the more orthodox', then they are the orthodox ones."

"There are many factions in academia and many different claims. But this is the most heretical of all the heretical ideas—almost half a step over the line into true heresy," Morris sighed. "Yet the many manuscripts left from the Critt Kingdom do not let us dodge this problem."

"Let us say those cultists hold a few pieces of the truth," Duncan shook his head lightly. "But that does not change the fact that their faith is very dangerous to the world as it is now. No matter what their Lord was like before the age of the Deep Sea, Its current state is… tsk tsk."

Morris listened, and then he suddenly came back to himself.

He woke from the calm mood of discussing scholarship with an old acquaintance and stared at Duncan in alarm: "Wait, by that you mean… could it be that you…"

"I happened to meet It once," Duncan thought about it. He felt he should at least offer some weighty information to the old gentleman. After all, he had taken so much knowledge from this scholar for free that he felt a bit guilty. "How should I put it… It was so miserable that even I could hardly bear to look, and there was no hope of recovery at all. I do not think those Sun believers' methods can bring their Lord back. If anything, I think they are only pushing their Lord toward even greater madness and distortion."

He paused, then looked at the old gentleman across from him: "Do you want me to tell you what It looks like now? Maybe you could gain some inspira—"

Morris had felt his own mind trembling ever since Duncan started to speak. When Duncan paused for breath, Morris finally seized his chance. He let out a sharp cry: “No need!”

Right after that, he seemed to feel his reaction was a bit rude. He hurriedly coughed twice, then spoke with serious respect: “This is not knowledge I should be touching.”

“…Oh, right, sorry,” Duncan froze for a moment, then waved his hand quickly. “Then let us not talk about that. Let us talk instead about the Black Sun faith in the Mortal Realm. Those cultists have kept trying to resurrect their Lord, yet their crude live sacrifices have never had any effect. In history, have they ever achieved any ‘results’?”

“The Sun heretics have caused plenty of destruction, but if we are talking about truly ‘reviving the Sun’, that is not something mortal power could achieve,” Morris recalled slowly. “As far as I know, there are only a few records of the Black Sun’s power appearing on a large scale in history.

“The earliest record was in the Late Chaotic Dynasty. After the collapse of the Critt Ancient Kingdom, many unresolved historical problems piled up over a long time. Several city?states broke out into constant wars and famines. The Sun heretics took advantage of the chaos and carried out a bloody great sacrificial rite in a city?state named Charon. In the end they summoned a gigantic living fireball. That fireball floated over Charon for five days before it finally faded, and in the end it melted the whole city?state into a single piece of glass.

“Another time was in the classical Age of City?States. The exact cause is unknown now. All we know is that several small city?states at the edge of the civilized world vanished in a single night. According to eyewitness accounts, a huge glowing rift opened in the sky, and a Sun Wheel rose

within it. The city?states were pulled up out of the sea by a huge force, torn into long narrow strips, and then fell into that rift.

“The most recent case happened at the very beginning of the New City? State Calendar, and it was also the strangest. That disaster left no eyewitness reports or records of damage at all. There was no proof, no records, no one who knew or remembered. We cannot even say for sure what year it happened or where it took place…”

Duncan listened in bafflement. At last he could not help speaking: “No one knows it even happened? How can that count as the Black Sun’s power appearing on a large scale? People do not even know which city?state was attacked?”

“Yes, that is how strange it was. This already went beyond what a normal scholar would study, but my position at the Truth Academy let me see some related documents,” Morris nodded, his face very serious. “That event did happen, because one morning a line of words suddenly appeared on the most sacred Chronicle Pillar of the Flamebearer Church.

“That one line mentioned a city?state that simply does not exist. It had only a single sentence:

‘Last message from Willheim. The Black Sun descended from history. We failed.’”

Chapter 181: History, corruption, and the Black Sun

That one line that suddenly appeared on the Chronicle Pillar. A city?state no one knew. A battle no one knew. A failure and sacrifice no one knew—a stretch of history that existed in no one's memory, leaving behind only this faint trace in the world after it died.

And even that extremely short sentence had probably cost the lives of more Flamebearers than anyone could count before it could be delivered into the Mortal Realm.

After hearing Morris's story, Duncan fell into thought once his brief shock passed.

The Flamebearer Church… he knew the rough situation of this sect.

After learning that this world had a "Four Gods faith", he had become deeply interested in these deities that had such a huge effect on the workings of the mortal world. The book Morris had previously sent him also happened to contain a lot about the Four Gods Church. Duncan had read up on the churches of all four True Gods, and among these Four Gods, the "Flamebearers" were the most unusual in his eyes.

The core of the Flamebearers' faith—their "belief"—was completely different from that of the believers of the other three Gods. The believers of the other three Gods followed storm, wisdom, and death, all concepts that were fairly easy to understand. The Flamebearers, however, followed something far more elusive: "history".

History was the memory of civilization, passed down like fire through the changing years. That was the core of the Flamebearers' belief. They thought that civilization began with "fire" and had used "fire" as its symbol ever since. In this world there were countless threats trying to disturb or twist the passing on of this flame. To fight those threats and keep the flame of civilization passing on steadily was their mission.

The Flamebearers followed and worshiped the Everburning Ember, Tarrigan, a giant who stood at the Dawn of Civilization. It was said that He kept and guarded the first bonfire mortals ever lit, and made that bonfire into a part of His own body. From the jumps and branching of the flames He told the correct history, and carved it into His own flesh. As civilization kept moving forward, this giant grew larger and larger. When He finally grew to His full size, mortal civilization in the world would gain true safety. No one would ever again be able to threaten the correct passing on of history—not even Subspace would be able to erase civilization.

That was the original text in the book Morris had sent. It was also the most important passage in the Flamebearers' scripture, the Flame Gospel.

In Duncan's view, the last part of that description was probably only the believers' wishful thinking, a big promise drawn by the Church, with a level of credibility that was open to doubt. But the part about the Flamebearers guarding history should all be true.

History could be corrupted, so of course it could also be protected—and the reverse was also true.

"…So they already did it once back then…" Duncan suddenly muttered, looking thoughtful.

"What did you say?" Morris did not react at first. "Did it once back then? What do you mean…"

“Nothing, I was just talking to myself,” Duncan shook his head lightly, then looked very seriously at the old gentleman in front of him. “The information you brought is very important.”

“The information I brought?” Morris was a little confused. “You mean that third record I just mentioned? The message that appeared on the Flamebearers’ Chronicle Pillar?”

Duncan nodded slightly, then suddenly frowned: “But there is something I am very curious about. Does the Black Sun have the divine authority to corrupt history?”

“This…” Morris hesitated. This clearly went beyond the knowledge range of a ‘history expert’. “I am not very clear on the matter of the Black Sun’s divine authority. Only experts who specialize in fighting Eldritch Gods would know that. But as far as I know, in theory the Black Sun should not have that ability…”

Duncan nodded, deep in thought. Morris watched this “Subspace shadow” in front of him with growing unease.

This “Mr. Duncan” always behaved with great courtesy and patience. He discussed academic issues with Morris, asking questions now and then and pondering the answers. The atmosphere was just like it had been when Morris last visited the antique shop. But the phantoms and noise that sometimes rose in his mind kept reminding Morris that he was walking along the edge of an abyss.

“Mr. Duncan” seemed to have become interested in the Flamebearers, in the “corruption and protection of history”. Why was that? Was this being, who likely came from Subspace, plotting something? Did the God of Wisdom Rahm have Morris stay behind and contact him in order to gain information on this point? What was the relationship between this Subspace shadow and the God of Wisdom? Were they in some kind of struggle?

Was he now taking part in a game between deities? Was he serving as the God of Wisdom's eyes and ears, spying on the other side?

All kinds of tangled thoughts rose and fell in Morris's mind. He became even more cautious. Once he realized what "role" he might be playing, he even felt a sudden sense of duty. It was as if Rahm stood behind him, watching this "Mr. Duncan" through his eyes.

While the old gentleman drifted off into wild thoughts, Duncan finally finished his own pondering. Duncan suddenly raised his head and muttered, half curious, half rueful: "Those 'Sun heretics' have done so many things, yet they are still active today… Haven't the normal people of the city?states ever thought about wiping out this group of madmen once and for all?"

"Wiping out a cult of an Eldritch God is easier said than done," Morris woke from his thoughts and shook his head without thinking. "Heretical faith is like mercury entering the body. It seeps through every crack. No matter how many you destroy, new ones will always appear. In the end, it is because the 'deity' behind them is still moving. As long as that Eldritch God still exists, Its corruption and infiltration of mortals will never stop. Even if all the adults in a city?state died and only the purest newborns were left, some of those newborns would still naturally grow minds that could be tempted…"

Morris spoke and shook his head. "Some people just live their lives quietly, honest and hardworking for most of their years. But because of a single moment of weakness after a setback, or a single wavering line of fear, or because they see something they should not see, or hear of something they should not know, they become heretics' tools overnight. Their minds fill with forbidden knowledge. They put on black robes and turn into believers of an Eldritch God. How can you ever fully clean away that kind of heretical corruption?"

As he said this, the old gentleman glanced at Duncan again without meaning to. His eyes grew a little strange.

Duncan looked puzzled: “Why are you looking at me like that?”

“Forgive my rudeness,” Morris took a light breath and gathered his courage. “But should you not be very familiar with this kind of… corruption among mortals?”

At first Duncan did not understand. It took him two seconds to catch Morris’s meaning, and his face turned helpless. “I do not do that sort of thing. I normally obey the law. When I see cultists, I even go and report them to the nearest constable of my own accord.”

Morris: “…?”

The old gentleman clearly had a bellyful of words in that instant, but he did not dare say a single one of them.

Duncan felt the topic had gone crooked. Before Morris could speak, Duncan quickly waved his hand: “I get what you mean. The believers of Eldritch Gods in the mortal world are only the ‘surface’. The real problem is that the Eldritch Gods themselves cannot be destroyed. Their corruption is like lingering poison, breeding crop after crop of cultists. Even if the Guardians fought for ten thousand years, they could never finish the cleanup. But is the Black Sun’s influence really that strong? I have seen that poor fellow. It is almost dead. Forget interfering in the mortal world—just speaking a word to me takes a last flare of dying strength. And even like that, It can still corrupt the Mortal Realm?”

Morris’s mouth twitched at once: “No matter how bad the Black Sun’s state is, that is only in your eyes. We… are all just fragile mortals…”

A strange feeling rose in Duncan’s heart. For a moment he wanted to tell the old gentleman: “I am human too. In what way do I not look human to you?”

But for the sake of the old man’s mental and physical health, he held the words back.

After blurting out what was on his mind, Morris seemed to think of something else. He paused, then added: “But your doubt may point to the key of the problem. If the Black Sun’s condition is really as bad as you say, Its corruption of the mortal world should not be this strong. At the very least it should not make the Sun heretics so hard to deal with… All of this may still be connected to those beings called the ‘Sun Spawn’.”

“The Sun Spawn…” Duncan muttered, thoughtful. He could not help thinking again of that tall, thin black silhouette that had appeared in Shirley’s dream before.

He did not have any clear proof, but he still felt that thing was very likely related to the legendary “Sun Spawn”.

The Black Sun was already in its twilight years and no longer had the strength to shine on this world. Yet Its spawn had gone on until today, continuing the Black Sun’s influence in another way. Because of that, the Suntists could not be wiped out, and their harm only grew greater.

But even here, one problem still had no answer:

The Black Sun did not have the ability to corrupt history, and Its spawn certainly did not.

Yet in the early years of the New City?State Calendar, the message from that city?state forgotten by history, Willheim, had said that “the Black Sun descended from history”. Now the city?state of Pland also showed signs of history being corrupted. What did that mean?

Could it be that… someone was “helping” the Black Sun to be resurrected from history?

Chapter 182: A Peaceful Tomorrow Will Still Come

The noise in his mind rose and fell, as if a huge source of interference was sometimes drawing close to his brain and sometimes drifting away. The antique shop in his field of vision stayed mostly stable, yet from time to time something dark flashed between the shelves, as if trying to show the reckless visitor the sinister Truth from Subspace.

Morris sat carefully at the counter, pulling back his thoughts and emotions. In the brief clarity granted to him by the God of Wisdom Rahm, he tried his best, within his limits, to think through one question after another.

The conversation was still going on. Until the “Mr. Duncan” across from him had said his fill, he, as the “conversation partner”, had to keep accompanying him.

However, Duncan was not speaking at this moment. He had also fallen into thought, thinking about things related to the Black Sun and the history of corruption.

That dead, yet noise-filled silence lasted for who knew how long before Morris suddenly heard a deep voice from across the table: “One last question. If something really is Corrupting history, how should that problem be solved?”

“Something is really… Corrupting history?” Morris raised his head a bit slowly and looked at Duncan in confusion. “Who are you talking about?”

“No matter who it is,” Duncan said calmly. “It might be Subspace, it might be the Black Sun, it might be some other Heretic God. If something is trying to Corrupt history, then how should it be dealt with? How do the Flamebearers handle that kind of crisis?”

Morris froze for a second, then shook his head hesitantly: “I… I’m sorry. I can’t answer that. It is already beyond what I know. Even among the Flamebearers, I’m afraid only the strongest Saints or Chosen Ones know the secrets of how history runs. Most Flamebearers are actually like the Guardians of the Storm Church. In daily life they only wipe out Heretics and carry out purification against corruption and the like. After all, a true corruption of history is almost impossible to happen…”

“…Right. It’s my question that’s too deep. It’s hard to make you answer this,” Duncan sighed softly. He realized his curiosity was too strong and had probably put a lot of pressure on the old Mr. in front of him, so he simply ended the topic. “Then let’s stop here for today.”

A wave of unprecedented relief rose in his chest, and Morris let out a long breath.

His head had grown groggy again a while ago. His thoughts broke off again and again. Many questions floated up in his mind, but he could not put them together. Now that Duncan was willing to end the talk on his own, Morris could not have wished for more.

Duncan raised his head and looked at the sky outside through the nearby glass window.

By the time of day, there was still a while before sunset, but the gloomy sky had already made it completely dark outside. The gas streetlamps lit up early, their pale yellow glow shining on the streets. Against the background of heavy dark clouds, the Lower City of Pland looked as if it had been thrown into the veil of night ahead of time.

“The weather looks bad,” Duncan withdrew his gaze and looked at the old man across from him. “Do you want to stay? Nina should have finished cooking by now.”

Morris’s heart started pounding at once. All of a sudden, he remembered a saying popular at the Truth Institute, used to describe the maddest and most legendary scholars who chased after knowledge— Swam in Subspace, bragged in front of an Eldritch God, watched the Gods’ war at the scene, and mooched a bowl of soup cooked by a Retainer.

If he treated this antique shop, already occupied by “Mr. Duncan”, as Subspace, if Mr. Duncan’s rank was equal to that of a God, and if there really was a struggle between this Subspace Shadow and the God of Wisdom… then he had already accomplished three of the four great sacred miracles…

At this point, if he went upstairs for a bowl of soup, he might actually be promoted to “legendary” on the spot!

Morris was a little surprised that he still had the strength to think about such nonsense right now. At the same time, he carefully gathered his words: “Actually…”

“Actually, you want to leave, right?” Duncan nodded before the old Mr. could finish. He still had some self-awareness. “Even though I want to say the weather is bad and staying for a bowl of hot soup might be better for your health, it looks like, compared with the comfort a bowl of soup would bring, the pressure of sitting in front of me right now is even greater?”

Morris hurriedly stood up and nodded along: “To be honest, every second is torture—of course, I don’t mean any offense, it’s just…”

“No need to say it, I get it,” Duncan waved his hand, a bit helpless. “If we could meet in a more relaxed way, I would really like to talk with you

properly about history and the Gods. I'm very interested in knowledge—the kind of interest without any malice. But this time, it looks like it won't work."

Morris stood beside the counter and fell silent after hearing this. After quite a while, he finally met Duncan's gaze: "To be honest, I drifted off several times just now and almost forgot the 'truths' I saw. Your… curiosity and friendliness felt so real. You talked with me like a friend. This is the first time I've met someone like you who is so friendly…"

The old Mr. got stuck. For a moment he really could not find a positive word. Duncan saw this and laughed: "If you can't find a good word, then don't. Just don't go and report me to anyone after you leave."

"No, no, no! I would never do that!" Morris waved his hands at once, as if he was afraid Duncan would misunderstand. "No matter what, you truly saved Heidi's life, and you have always been friendly. I have no reason to report you—besides…"

The old Mr. hesitated, then spread his hands with a bitter smile: "Judging from how you look, you probably aren't afraid of being 'reported' anyway…"

"It would feel troublesome," Duncan said casually, "but probably not a big trouble."

Then he paused for a moment, looked up toward the second floor, and then looked back at Morris: "If the weather improves tomorrow, Nina will go to school as usual."

"Nina…" Morris blinked. He remembered the arc of blazing flame he had seen, and he remembered what he had just discussed with Duncan, especially the part about the Black Sun. Combined with Duncan's attitude

just now, he already vaguely guessed something in his heart. “Nina… is she connected to what those Suntists worship…”

He did not finish the question, because Duncan gently shook his head.

“Nina is just Nina. You don’t need to be curious about the secrets behind her,” Duncan said softly. “Treat her like you always do, and then nothing will happen.”

“…I understand,” Morris lowered his head slightly. For some reason, after hearing Duncan’s words, he felt even more relieved than before. He stepped back two steps. “Then I should take my leave. Please say goodbye to Nina for me—I am not really in a state to ‘look’ at her again right now.”

Duncan made a sound of agreement, came out from behind the counter, and walked the old Mr. to the front door.

There were hardly any pedestrians left on the street. Only rows of streetlamps lit the cloud-covered district. A cold wind blew between the buildings, circling back and forth, and the dampness in the air grew heavier.

Morris pulled his coat tighter and pressed down the short top hat on his head. But before he walked to his car, he still could not help stopping. He turned back to look at Duncan, who was still standing in the shop doorway.

What he saw was a middle-aged man with a calm smile. The distant street view still shook from time to time, but it no longer looked like the terrifying Anomaly it had at the start.

“Mr. Duncan,” Morris suddenly said, “you actually like this place a lot, don’t you?”

“That’s right, I like it here quite a bit,” Duncan laughed and waved to the old man. “So go home without worry. Pland will safely welcome tomorrow—and every day after.”

Morris took off his hat, gave Duncan a small wave, then turned and walked toward the car parked by the roadside.

Duncan did not look away until the car started up and disappeared at the end of the street.

But he did not go back inside right away. Instead, he stood at the door, lost in thought.

The first question he thought about was whether the Old Gentleman would report him after going home…

His conclusion was that the chance was very, very small. If he had only been an ordinary cultist, or even a slightly higher-ranking Sun priest, then as a believer of the True Gods, Morris would have had a one hundred percent chance of reporting him afterward. But judging from today, in the other party's eyes he probably looked more like an Elder Gods-level being. That actually made the Old Gentleman's chance of reporting him drop to almost zero.

The reason was simple: to report a few cultists, two Constables would be enough to wipe them out. To report a Cult priest, a few Guardians could cut him down on the spot. But if what was entrenched in this place was a Subspace Eldritch God… then what level would you even report that to?

Forget about the local Cathedral—reporting it to the city's Bishop would be useless as well…

It would be more reliable to go back and mutter a few words to the God of Wisdom he believed in than to report it to the Church.

And even aside from all that, if Morris really did go to the Church to report him, Duncan still would not care much.

After all, even Vanna-F, the Inquisitor who stood at the peak of combat power in the Storm Church, still looked a bit weak in his eyes…

Compared with such minor details, what Duncan cared about more right now was actually Nina's condition.

That surging, burning arc of flame… this was the "truth" Morris had seen on Nina with the Eye of Truth given to him by the God of Wisdom.

"A shard of the Sun, huh…" Duncan lifted his head and looked at the dark sky outside, muttering softly to himself. "Just what the hell is the Sun in this world…"

Chapter 183: The Invasion After nightfall

“Teacher just left like that?” Nina came down to the first floor and widened her eyes in surprise when she heard that Morris had already left. Then she complained: “Uncle, why didn’t you ask him to stay a bit longer? The weather is so bad and you still let Teacher go…”

“It would be completely dark if he stayed any longer,” Duncan turned around and locked the front door, then spoke casually as he walked toward the stairs. “He drove here. A bit of rain won’t affect him much.”

“But Teacher didn’t look very well,” Nina followed him, muttering as she climbed the stairs. “He should have rested a bit more…”

Duncan thought for a moment. He figured that if the Old Gentleman really stayed here to rest a bit longer, then it would not be just “not feeling well” anymore. It might turn into ten straight Will Tests all failing. Then forget about tomorrow’s Sun—he might not even see tonight’s World’s Wound…

But there was no way he could explain that to Nina, so he only brushed it off with a few casual words and went to the dining table on the second floor.

Nina had already prepared a hot meal—beet soup, toasted bread, vegetable rolls, and sliced ham.

There was clearly enough for one more person.

“If we can’t finish, we’ll save it for tomorrow morning,” Nina muttered. Then she looked up at Duncan with some curiosity. “What did you talk about with Teacher? I couldn’t hear clearly upstairs just now, but it sounded like you two were talking quite happily…”

Duncan quietly watched Nina. He had been watching her like this for a while, watching this girl moving about busily.

She was just like always, always smiling. Even when she complained, she never really looked angry. She kept busy with this and that, as if she always had endless things to do, endless energy to use, and she was always looking forward to tomorrow.

Duncan could only see this kind of Nina. He did not have eyes that could see through reality like Morris, and he could not see the surging flame inside Nina.

If he had not just heard it with his own ears, he really would never have imagined that the shard of the Sun that tugged at the nerves of countless people was quietly “sleeping” right here, right under his nose.

The shard of the Sun… what exactly was it?

Duncan had once thought it was a tangible supernatural item. Later, through various clues, he confirmed that it was a solar prominence that had been stripped away. Yet now he had discovered that this thing was very likely sleeping inside Nina’s body…

If that thing really came from the “star” he knew, then what kind of change would a star have to go through to peel off such a strange… “shard”?

“Uncle Duncan?” Nina noticed the gaze from across the table and twisted her body in slight awkwardness. “Do I have something stuck on my face?”

“…No, nothing at all,” Duncan shook his head lightly. As he lowered his head to break the bread, he asked as if casually: “By the way, have you felt

unwell recently? That strange dream from before… has it appeared again?”

“No,” Nina waved her hand. “The hypnosis Miss Heidi did for me last time worked pretty well. I haven’t had any strange dreams since then, and I’ve felt energetic every day.”

She paused for a moment, then looked at Duncan with some worry: “Uncle, is something wrong with you? I feel like… you’ve been a bit strange since you finished talking with Mr. Morris… Ah, it can’t be my last test score…”

“No, stop imagining things. Your Teacher didn’t come here to complain about you,” Duncan raised an eyebrow. “Eat first, eat first.”

Nina answered and lowered her head to eat. At that moment, though, Duncan seemed to sense something and looked in confusion toward a certain direction outside the window.

……

In the Lower City, deep in a shabby, dim alley, gas lamps lit in a hurry finally drove away the surrounding darkness before the veil of night completely covered the streets. In the dull light from the gas lamps, Shirley lay on the windowsill, a bit dazed as she looked at the dark street outside.

The clatter of chains rubbing against each other came from behind her, followed by Dog’s voice: “You’re leaning out to look again? What’s there to see?”

“I just can’t sleep. It’s so early and there’s nothing to do,” Shirley muttered. “I’m so bored…”

“…How about we go out tomorrow and keep making trouble for cultists?”

“…Feels like we’ll still find nothing,” Shirley thought for a bit and shook her head. “I don’t know if the people from the Church suddenly got better at

their jobs, but lately the cultists in the city-state seem to have been caught clean. Even you can't smell their stink anymore…"

"The Suntists who were active in the city recently really are gone. Maybe they really were all caught," Dog came closer and flopped down lazily at Shirley's feet. "But I don't think you're bored because of that at all…"

Shirley rolled her eyes at once: "Then what else could it be?"

"…Are you thinking about 'over there'?" Dog lifted his head, faint light flickering in his hollow blood-red eye sockets. "Thinking about that warm house, that bright room, the hot meals, the days when someone called you to get up and urged you to eat. Or… are you thinking about that Subspace Retainer called Nina? Maybe even that Duncan…"

"Damn it, shut up! You're so annoying!" Shirley yanked hard on the chain in her hand, cutting Dog off roughly. "I'm not some whining little brat. How could I be that weak!"

Dog did not care at all about Shirley's rough reaction: "…Longing for light and warmth isn't weakness. It only proves you are still a Human."

"Ugh…" Shirley suddenly shivered, then looked disgusted. "Why the hell are you suddenly so mushy? And talking all fancy? 'Proves I'm still a Human'… Are you praising me or saying I haven't improved at all in all these years?"

"…Don't think that just because you've been fused with me, a Abyssal Demon, for eleven years, you've really turned into a Demon too. There's nothing wrong with calmly admitting the human side of yourself," Dog shook his ugly big head. "Besides, don't forget, the thing linking you and me isn't just this chain—how could I not understand it when your emotions change?"

“…Shut up,” Shirley turned her face away and looked outside irritably. “If you keep nagging, I’ll really take you to see Nina tomorrow. Then I’ll keep Nina company, you can keep Mr. Duncan company, and both of us will have a bright future—see if that doesn’t scare you till you pee yourself!”

Dog finally fell silent.

After a brief silence, Shirley could not help nudging the Abyssal Hound beside her with the tip of her foot, taking the initiative to break the quiet: “Stop worrying so much. I still have you with me, don’t I?”

“You’re even mushier than I am,” Dog shifted, the chain clanking. “Stop talking. If you keep going, I’m going to throw up—and then there will be another hole in the floor.”

The Abyssal Hound kept grumbling, but through the spirit link between them, Shirley could feel that “Dog”, who had almost eaten her alive and then raised her to adulthood, suddenly felt much better.

In the dim dusk and the faint glow of the streetlamps, the thin girl curled her lips, hiding the small smile on her face.

This was good. Everything had gone back on track. The familiar days had returned, and she only needed to keep living them. She must not think about peace and warmth that did not belong to her, especially when that peaceful, warm place still had a Shadow from Subspace lurking in it.

That warmth was far too dangerous.

Shirley let out a soft breath.

But in the next second, she frowned slightly. She felt as if something malicious was approaching, and the hairs on her back stood up.

Dog also suddenly rose from his lying position. Black smoke and flames burst from the huge Abyssal Hound’s body. The red light in his hollow

blood-colored eye sockets flared as he swept the room with sharp wariness and hostility.

The room was dark. To save money, Shirley had blown out the Oil lamp on the table the moment the streetlamps lit up, so now only the light from outside shone into the room. In the dim, spreading light, the simple furniture inside cast mottled, strange Shadows on the floor and walls.

In the shabby home, everything was in plain sight, familiar and clear.

Yet for some reason, Shirley suddenly felt that all the furnishings in her home were a bit strange. In the staggered lights and shadows, in the corners of the table and chairs and the gaps at the foot of the bed, an unfamiliar, wrong kind of aura kept seeping out!

Shirley tightened the chain in her hand on instinct: “Dog!”

“I know,” Dog growled at the same time. “I’m looking! Something is coming in here… surrounding us… damn! What is this, my eyes are going blurry!”

Before the Abyssal Hound finished speaking, Shirley suddenly noticed that the light from the streetlamps shining in through the window was starting to twist and dim!

It was as if a heavy black curtain suddenly fell over the whole house. The street scene that had been clear a second ago turned blurry in an instant. The light from the streetlamps was cut into broken pieces, scattered as pale glimmers across the room. Then those pale glimmers and the shadows everywhere started writhing all at once. Together with a series of nauseating, low whispers and strange sounds, several figures abruptly surfaced from between the light and shadow—

They wore tattered black robes, and the arms exposed beneath the robes were thin as sticks. A pitch-black Black Codex hung at each of their waists.

The Black Codex looked soaked in inky filth, with black, suspicious liquid seeping and dripping from the books without stopping. On each of their chests hung an iron emblem like a wreath of thorns, and in the center of each emblem a pale, muddy flame flickered.

The black-robed figure in the lead raised a hand and pointed at Shirley. Muffled, hoarse syllables that no Human throat could make came from under the hood: “You shall perish…”

Dog’s shout finally reached Shirley’s ears: “Damn it, it’s a Ender!!!”

Chapter 184: Attack of the Enders

Dog's cracked, gong-like roar exploded like thunder and echoed through the shabby little house. The attackers in tattered black robes, who looked like ascetics, were clearly shocked when they heard a Abyssal Demon speak rational human words—and in the next second, something even more shocking happened.

Shirley flicked the chain. She swung the Abyssal Hound in her hand in a wide circle and smashed it toward the nearest "Ender".

She actually did not know much about the Enders. She only knew in a vague way that they were also a group of cultists, even more crazy and extreme. The "lord" they worshiped was even Subspace itself. Shirley did not know why a bunch of such madmen suddenly crawled out in the city-state of Pland, or why these madmen had found her. But that was not important—

Her experience crawling through gutters and back alleys had taught her one rule: when you met danger, you did not waste time thinking about things you could not figure out. Swinging your arms and beating the hell out of it worked better than anything else.

The huge Abyssal Hound howled through the air like a cannonball. In an instant it smashed into one of the robed "preachers". After a dull thud of flesh and bone, the attacker flew backward, slammed hard into a pillar not far away, twisted into a strange angle, and then slid to the floor.

Shirley yanked on the chain and dragged Dog back to her side, then swung him again toward the next enemy.

But in that brief moment, the black-robed figures had already reacted. They clearly had more combat experience than the lowest the Suntists Shirley had met before. Even though this rare fighting style had stunned them for a second, they still quickly pulled themselves together and scattered the instant the Abyssal Hound came whipping toward them.

One of them dodged past Dog's bony skull by a hair's breadth, slipped to the side, and raised a hand to point at Shirley. From under the hood came a hoarse, gloomy shout: "Thou Shalt Grow Weary!"

"What the hell are you mumbling about?!" Shirley was already in a foul mood. Hearing that muttering voice made her even angrier. She stepped, twisted her waist, and turned. The chain in her hand whistled out. Dog's skeletal body slammed into the screeching Ender and sent him flying.

But in the few swings it took to do that, Shirley suddenly felt something wrong with her body.

She felt a bit tired. It was not very serious, but the tiredness was real.

At the same time, her head started to buzz. Her anger rushed in her chest like a wild beast she could not hold back. A violent urge to drop all defense, charge straight in, and die together with the enemy slammed in her mind. It almost made her dizzy.

A strange creaking, cracking sound suddenly reached her ears. Shirley turned toward the sound and saw the attacker she had just smashed away getting up from the floor. He was covered in blood. Many of his bones were clearly broken, yet this "preacher" seemed to ignore pain that would have made an ordinary person faint. Blood still sprayed from him as he raised both hands high: "My hands and feet shall not die to the flesh—The curse!"

After that muttered shout, the Enders around them seemed to gain endless courage and strength. In the next second, Shirley watched in shock as these madmen's bodies started to change.

Their skinny, bony frames began to swell and twist. Thick bone spurs and tough, whip-like muscle cords grew from their limbs and stretched out like weapons. Their bodies tore and reshaped in great pain, turning ugly and monstrous, twisted and profane.

Yet these fanatics seemed to fall into a strange ecstasy in this pain. They cheered, shouted, praised—and then they rushed at Shirley.

"What the hell are these things?!" Shirley of course did not sit still and let them do as they pleased. The moment the first Ender's body began to change, she swung the chain so fast it hummed and hurled Dog at the closest enemy. The impact broke the target's tendons and bones. He did not die on the spot, but his mutation stopped at once.

However, just that single attack made Shirley feel even more clearly tired than before. A sharper, more painful wave of violent impulse stabbed through her mind.

She even began to hear noises that did not exist. Every muscle in her body felt like it was being gnawed by invisible teeth, full of cruel pain, as if every fiber was about to tear itself free.

"These 'preachers' are madmen who chose to embrace Subspace! Their words and bodies carry corruption!" Dog's voice suddenly rang in Shirley's mind, more anxious than ever. "Don't let them keep yapping! Whoever opens his mouth, you smash him! Don't look into their eyes. Don't listen to their shouting!"

In a flash, a cold gleam appeared at the edge of Shirley's vision. She moved on instinct, trying to dodge, but a bone spur still grazed her and stabbed into

her arm. She hurriedly swung the chain to strike back and felt her hands and feet grow twice as heavy as before. This time, even black afterimages started to appear in her field of vision.

Another Ender took the chance to spread both arms and chant a vicious blessing: “Thou Shalt Not Heal…”

“Bang!”

“Get the hell out!” Shirley swung the dog in a full arc and smashed this raving preacher, who had already turned into a monster covered in bone spurs, straight into the wall. In the next second, she suddenly felt a sharp pain in her back.

A spear-like bone spur stabbed from a sneaky blind angle and drove deep into her back. If her body had not, after years of a Demon symbiotic pact, grown as tough and sturdy as a Abyssal Demon’s, that blow might have pierced straight through her.

Shirley’s body pitched forward against her will. Dog threw himself in front of the attacker who moved in to chase, opened his jaws, and spat out a blast of highly corrosive black flame mixed with acid.

The attacker was forced back for the moment, but Shirley’s state was terrible. She braced herself against the nearby wall, feeling blood run down her back without stopping, and feeling her muscles twitch out of control.

The corruption from the Enders was still working. Even though the Abyssal Demons’ resistance made her endure this Anomaly far better than an ordinary person, she had been caught off guard at the start and hit with weakening and The curse. Now she could clearly feel her body slowly sliding toward… a runaway state.

Her blood was boiling. The noise in her head grew louder and louder. Her muscles kept spasming. She saw smoke rising from the wound on her arm.

In that smoke, the torn flesh did not heal. Instead, ugly, disgusting flesh buds grew out bit by bit. Her blood writhed around the wound as if it had a life of its own, crawling and clumping, taking shape.

The wound on her back was probably in the same state.

"…Damn it, all that effort and I only took down three…"

Shirley spat blood to the side and grinned in a pained smile as she muttered.

"Already not bad," Dog's grumbling voice came from beside her. The Abyssal Hound sounded weak and listless. As Shirley's first barrier against corruption, he suffered even more from the Enders's influence. "These are priest-level ascetics, not the kind of rabble who crowd into a basement and let someone talk them into donating money… Fighting them like this was almost like storming the Cathedral in the city… You did not lose out at all."

"Damn it, a bunch of grown men this big, ganging up on one harmless little young lady like me—Lord above, that's shameless." Shirley lifted her head. Her face was covered in blood as she stared at the Enders gathering around her. Only viciousness shone in her eyes. "What did I ever do to you?"

Three Enders were still standing. All of them had turned into skeletal, blood-soaked monsters. Their tattered robes hung from their mutated bodies like The shroud, making them look even more grim and frightening in the dimness.

They did not answer Shirley, of course. Hunters did not bargain with prey.

Shirley coughed up blood and lifted her head to look around.

There had been a lot of noise in the fight, yet no Guardian had come, and not a single neighbor had been disturbed. Outside the window, the world was still hazy. The street was eerily quiet.

Clearly, some kind of “barrier” covered the whole house. The attackers had done their prep work very well before they struck.

All the furniture was destroyed.

The walls and pillars were ready to collapse.

The only wardrobe had been smashed to pieces by a stray hit in the fight. The few clothes inside, along with the little drawer where she hid her coins, had fallen to the floor, soaked in filthy blood and eaten away by acid.

The most valuable thing in the house, the oil lamp, had also been knocked over. The glass shade lay shattered across the floor.

“I only have so few things, and you still smashed them to bits,” Shirley finally could not hold herself up anymore. Her body slowly slid toward the floor, but she still lifted her head, staring at the enemy who was raising his bone spurs to finish her. “You bastards… I’m going to spray blood right in your face later…”

The bone spurs stabbed down through the air.

Then, in a blink, they slowed, leaving layer upon layer of afterimages, and finally stopped in midair.

A tongue of green flame suddenly flared into being in the room that should have been fully sealed by the barrier. In the fire, a huge, ferocious skeletal bird circled in the air. A shrill, strange female voice stabbed into Shirley’s ears—

“Our warrior is in combat with the enemy… teleportation successful!”

—

Chapter 185: Each Safe and Sound

An Undead bird made of phantom flesh and crystal-clear bone, a sharp and piercing strange female voice, roaring green flames—and a sentence no one could fully understand.

Shirley's dazed mind suddenly cleared. She stared in shock at the strange bird that had rushed in. The bird circled once more in the air. As it circled, the figures of the Enders around her froze one by one in mid-motion, locked into weird poses. It was just like what happened in a "cinema" when the people on the screen suddenly stopped moving because the film jammed.

One of these monsters had even been caught while stepping forward, so his body almost hung in midair. It looked eerie and frightening… and a little ridiculous.

The Undead bird circled again. This time, a door and vortex of green fire opened in the air. A tall figure stepped out of it and came to stand in front of Shirley.

"I remember I told you that you can ask for help when you run into trouble," Duncan lowered his head and gazed at the blood-soaked girl lying on the floor with a calm gaze. "Why didn't you call me?"

"I… I forgot," Shirley blinked. The moment Duncan appeared, she noticed that the corruption and The curse from the Enders were fading from her at high speed. As the harsh noise and wild thoughts in her mind died down, her head slowly cleared. A strange, tangled look crossed her face. "My head

was a mess just now… Right, these guys kept howling like ghosts. They made my head spin…”

Duncan slowly turned his head and glanced at the attackers frozen in midair by AI’s High-Latency Strike.

It was his first time seeing such weird… things. They looked a bit like people and still wore scraps of human clothes, but their bodies had mutated so much they were hardly human anymore. Their limbs were twisted flesh, bone spurs jutted from every joint, and their faces wore crazed yet almost comical expressions—almost even uglier than Dog.

Duncan frowned and looked back at Shirley: “They did this to you? Where did they all come from?”

“They’re the ones who beat me up!” Shirley raised her voice at once. The moment the words left her mouth, she felt like something about that sounded off, but she quickly pushed the feeling aside. “I don’t know where they came from either. Dog said they’re Enders, those madmen who follow Subspace…”

“Enders… the ones who follow Subspace?” Duncan had still been somewhat relaxed, but his expression suddenly shifted when he heard the latter half of her words. It was as if he had thought of something. He looked at AI at once. “Don’t toss them yet!”

While he spoke, the frozen bodies of the Enders began to flicker, but AI quickly flapped her wings. The three attackers who had almost been pushed out of the Mortal Realm snapped back into the Mortal Realm, and AI’s sharp cry rang through the room: “Network connected, network connected!”

“Send them up to the ship,” Duncan nodded to the Pigeon Spirit. “I’ll meet them on deck.”

“Mission received! Mission received!”

AI shrieked twice, then quickly traced a fiery spiral in the air. In the rising flames of her spirit form, the three Enders vanished in an instant.

In the dim room, only Duncan, Dog, and Shirley remained, plus three corpses not far away that had been smashed flat into “preacher pancakes” by the meteor dog.

Shirley stared blankly at the scene before her, watching as those Subspace believers who had almost killed her and Dog disappeared from the room in the blink of an eye. The “battle” had ended in such a strange and easy way that it hardly counted as a battle at all.

Mr. Duncan had not even made a move. From start to finish, he had not cared what tricks or special curses the Enders had. He had simply appeared here, taken a bit of interest in those people, and then casually snatched them away, as if he had picked up a few stones by the roadside.

He might not even have realized that those cultists “had combat power”.

Just then, Duncan’s voice broke into Shirley’s wandering thoughts: “How bad are your injuries?”

Shirley snapped out of the thought of “Mr. Duncan is terrifying”. Her first instinct was to act tough and pretend she did not care about her wounds. But just as she opened her mouth, she bared her teeth in pain with an “ow”. The stabbing pain in her back and the ache in her arm hit her at the same time, and she could not help cursing: “Damn, that hurts…”

Duncan looked at her with concern: “Should I take you to a hospital?”

“Absolutely not!” Shirley jolted upright at once. Still grimacing, she forced herself to sit up. “I don’t have any money…”

Duncan stared at her: “You look like this, and you’re worried about money?”

“I wasn’t finished,” Shirley finally sat all the way up. “My body isn’t like other people’s. If I go to a hospital, they’ll definitely notice. If I draw the Church’s attention, I won’t be able to explain it. And look—”

She spoke as she raised her arm so Duncan could see her wound.

The wound was healing. After the Enders’s curse and corruption faded, her self-healing had returned. The ugly gash no longer bled. The corrupted matter in the wound was being squeezed out by the writhing flesh, and the growth of new tissue was visible to the naked eye.

The worst wound on her back was also slowly recovering. It still hurt a lot, but Shirley knew she had survived this time.

“As long as those Enders don’t keep yapping nonstop, I’m not afraid of them,” Shirley lifted her chin stubbornly. “On a normal day, a little cut like this would never knock me flat on the floor… ow, ow, that hurts…”

A soft cracking sound came from not far away, cutting off Shirley’s muttering.

She and Duncan both turned toward the noise and saw it came from one of the dead Enders. At some point, his twisted body had turned into a gray-white mass like weathered rock. It began to crumble bit by bit. Fragments flaked off, and before they even hit the floor, they turned to dust and scattered.

As the preachers’ corpses weathered and fell apart, the room that had been wrapped in The Veil also began to change. The Shadows that had clung outside the window vanished quickly. The streetlamps outside returned to normal, and the unnatural Shadows and cold malice in every corner of the house faded away.

“…The Enders gave themselves to Subspace. Now it’s time to pay the price,” Dog answered the doubt on Duncan’s face in a dull voice. “These scum will be devoured by Subspace. They won’t leave even a single speck of dust in the Mortal Realm.”

“…So this kind of cultist is pretty eco-friendly when they die,” Duncan murmured. “Saves the trouble of cleaning up the scene.”

Then he turned back to Shirley: “Feeling better? If you’re a bit better, come with me.”

As he spoke, a flicker of eerie green flame appeared in the air. AI flew out of the fire, circled once, and landed on his shoulder.

“Go with you?” Shirley didn’t react for a moment. “Go where…”

“You weren’t planning to spend the night here, were you?” Duncan pointed at the wrecked room. “Does this place still look livable to you?”

Shirley slowly pushed herself up along the wall. Her gaze swept across the old house where she and Dog had depended on each other for so many years.

Broken furniture lay everywhere. Corroded scraps were scattered across the floor. Anything valuable or not had been destroyed completely.

There had never been much to begin with.

Shirley lowered her eyes and stayed silent for a while.

“It seems the patrolling Guardians didn’t notice anything here. We still have time to pack up,” Duncan sighed. He knew how Shirley felt now, but he had no idea how to comfort her. “But no matter what, you can’t live here anymore. Even if you ignore the smashed things, you have to think about whether more attackers will come later. We still don’t know why those Enders came after you, but they’ve already marked you…”

Duncan did not go on.

He knew Shirley was a child far more mature than she looked. This girl had grown up in a harsh environment. She knew what mattered.

“I’ll… pack my things,” Shirley said in a dull voice.

“Need any help?” Duncan asked.

“No,” Shirley shook her head. “There isn’t… much.”

She really did not have much.

Duncan waited only a short while. Shirley gathered the things she wanted to take from a few dark corners: just some unremarkable old items, including a tiny little doll that was almost falling apart, a few pieces of clothing that had not been destroyed, and two slightly bent little metal boxes that rattled with bits of change inside.

She put everything into a worn little case, then carried it over to Duncan and lowered her head obediently: “I’m done.”

Dog turned his head to look at the little case in Shirley’s hand and muttered in a low voice: “You’re taking all of that… so we’re not coming back, are we?”

Shirley stayed silent.

Duncan looked quietly at the girl in front of him. A gentle smile slowly appeared on his face.

He reached out and patted the girl’s hair.

“Come on. Let’s go home.”

green flame rose into the air. The Undead bird spread its wings in the fire, blocking Shirley’s last glimpse of the little house.

Chapter 186: Local Specialty from the City-State

On the first floor of the antique shop, Nina sat anxiously on the chair by the counter. From time to time she got up to peek out the display window, but all she saw was the empty street under the streetlamps. Then she went to check the front door again, making sure it was still tightly shut.

She had the urge to go out and take a look several times, but each time, just before her hand touched the doorknob, she stopped. In her mind she recalled Uncle's hurried instructions before he left—do not leave this door, stay home and wait for him to come back.

"Uncle really is something… he just had to go out after nightfall even though there's a curfew…" Nina sat back down behind the counter again, muttering to herself, "If the patrolling Guardians see him, they'll definitely detain him again, and it's so dangerous…"

She had no idea how many times she had muttered this already.

Then she finally heard a bit of noise at the door. Footsteps sounded suddenly, followed by the turning of the lock.

Nina snapped her head up toward the door. She saw the door being pushed open as the bell hanging there rang with a crisp, pleasant chime, and that familiar figure finally appeared in her sight.

"Nina, I'm back," Duncan looked at the girl hurrying over from beside the counter and smiled a little. "See, it's not that late."

Nina rushed over in a few quick steps and bumped her head into Duncan's chest. Right after that came a long string of complaints: "You call this not late? Do you know what time it is now? Going out when there's a curfew is so dangerous! And you didn't even say what you were going to do, you just told me to stay home and wait…"

Nina's nagging complaints were like a storm at sea, once they rose they went on and on. But then she noticed a small figure hiding behind Duncan, and her complaining stopped at once.

Shirley, carrying a small suitcase, ducked out from behind Duncan with her head down. A little stiff and nervous, she waved at Nina: "Nina… and me."

Duncan turned around and closed the shop's front door to keep nosy people from noticing anything. Nina, after seeing what Shirley looked like, opened her eyes wide: "Shirley?! You… why are you here, and with Uncle… Wait, you're covered in blood!"

"Ah, don't worry, don't worry," Shirley waved her hands in a panic. Even though the wound on her back had not fully healed, she still tried to show the same bright smile as always. "I just ran into a small problem. I'm fine…"

"How is that a small problem?!" Nina hurriedly grabbed the small suitcase from Shirley's hand and quickly checked the blood on her. She soon noticed the torn place on Shirley's clothes and was shocked pale. "You… how badly are you hurt? We have to find a doctor right away! You…"

"I really am fine, hey, calm down!" Shirley quickly caught Nina's hand, looking completely helpless. "Did you forget? I'm not an ordinary person…"

Nina opened her mouth, as if she still wanted to say something, but suddenly heard Duncan cough beside them.

“Ahem.” Duncan cut off the two girls’ increasingly chaotic exchange and fixed his gaze on Nina. “Don’t ask so much for now. Shirley’s injuries shouldn’t be a problem—you should take her upstairs to bathe and change clothes first. We’ll explain the details later.”

Nina’s eyes moved back and forth between Shirley and Duncan as she muddle?headedly agreed. Shirley rubbed her stomach, a little embarrassed: “Um… is there anything to eat… I’d like to eat something first…”

Maybe she had burned too much energy while healing her wounds. Right now she only felt ravenously hungry—the pain in her body seemed far less urgent in comparison.

“Ah, ah, yes!” Nina froze for a second, then reacted at once. “I actually cooked enough for one more person tonight… I’ll go heat it up for you!”

Nina ran up the stairs at full speed. The thudding of her footsteps faded away. Shirley stayed behind, a little dazed. She looked around and saw the familiar first?floor shop, the shelves filled with fake antiques, the not?so? clean display window, and Mr. Duncan standing nearby with a half?smile.

She stared for several seconds before she finally muttered softly: “I’m back again…”

“Yes, you’re back again.” Duncan smiled, bent down to pick up Shirley’s small suitcase, and started forward. “We’d better take this chance to talk about how to explain those injuries of yours, and come up with a reasonable reason for you to live here for a while. Though I don’t think we need to work too hard on that. Nina will be very happy to see you stay.”

Shirley stared blankly at his back for a moment, then suddenly came to her senses. She hurried to catch up with Duncan in a few steps, reaching for her suitcase as she spoke quickly: “I can carry it myself! I can…”

Duncan only shook his head with a smile and looked up ahead.

The pale, cold light of World’s Wound shone over the boundless sea. The gently rolling waves reflected fine, broken scales of light. The cool sea breeze from the veil of night blew across the deck and stirred the hem of the captain’s uniform.

Duncan stood on the deck of the Vanished, looking at the three “Enders” in front of him. Their minds had not yet recovered, but their bodies were slowly returning to human shape.

So these twisted, warped things could turn back into normal people after all?

Footsteps came from not far away. Duncan looked back and saw Alice’s silver?white long hair flying in the night wind—the doll in a long dress ran over through the darkness, shouting happily as she ran: “Captain, Captain, I just heard Mr. Goathead say you sent something to the deck again? Did you buy something from the human city?state again…”

Alice stopped mid?shout in shock. The doll, who had run out to watch the fun, skidded to a stop beside the captain and stared in confusion at the three “human?shaped creatures” lying on the deck.

After staring for quite a while, the doll finally turned her blank gaze toward Duncan: “Captain… are these also local specialties from the human city? state?”

“…You could call them that,” Duncan thought for a moment. “I really haven’t seen them anywhere else. They keep popping up one batch after another in the city?state.”

Alice let out a muddled “oh,” then raised a hand to scratch her hair. Her head felt itchy—as if a brain were about to grow in there, but somehow still refused to appear.

“They look… human, right?” the doll muttered. “Captain, why did you bring three of these things up here? You didn’t buy them, did you?”

“I didn’t buy them. I picked them up on the way.” Duncan answered this scatter?brained doll offhandedly while keeping his attention on the three “Subspace believers,” whose bodies had almost fully recovered their human form. He noticed that one of them already showed signs of waking, and only then did he quietly let out a breath.

It seemed AI’s teleportation process was as reliable as ever. These cultists were still alive, and they could even wake up.

So… could he also have AI teleport ordinary people to the ship in the future?

Duncan began to calculate in his heart, and his mood slowly improved.

He had always wanted to find some cultists to serve as “test subjects,” to test AI’s long?range teleportation ability, the special environment aboard the Vanished, and Alice’s Guillotine power, but he had never found a chance.

The Suntists in the city?state had been almost completely swept up by a crackdown from the Deep Sea Church, and were now all stuffed into Cathedrals around the city. The scattered cultists among the common folk had either fled or gone into hiding, and after searching for a long time, he still hadn’t found any. He had already put this idea aside for the moment, and had not expected to run into a situation like this tonight.

A few Enders who worshiped Subspace had popped up out of nowhere.

What else could Duncan say? He could only thank nature for its gifts…

As he was thinking this, the “gifts of nature” on the deck finally began to wake up.

One Ender suddenly twitched. A hoarse, low groan came from his throat. Then his thin, twig?like arms suddenly pushed his body up. This worshiper of Subspace sat up and stared in shock at the strange surroundings.

The gentle waves and the cold sea wind pricked at nerves twisted by the influence of Subspace. A mild, deep voice sounded beside him: “You’re awake.”

“This is…” The cultist slowly turned his head. Duncan and Alice’s figures were reflected in his clouded eyes. His dull brain took several seconds to start working again. Then he suddenly jumped to his feet to face Duncan with open hostility and even took a small step back. “Who are you?!”

“Oh, right, you’ve never seen me,” Duncan smiled as he watched the other two Enders slowly wake. His voice sank to a low rumble. “Welcome to the Vanished—you can call me Captain Duncan.”

“…The Vanished?!” The first cultist to awaken froze for a moment. He clearly knew the name. After a brief dazed pause, his eyes went wide. “This is… this is the ghost ship that came back from Subspace?!”

“That’s right. Looks like you understand the situation. That will make things easier between us.” Duncan nodded. “First, I have a few questions…”

He hadn’t even finished when the cultist across from him suddenly raised both hands high. A kind of wild joy seemed to flood the madman’s mind as he shouted at the top of his lungs: “O Subspace! You have finally opened Your gate to us! Immortality in Doomsday! Salvation in disaster! All things destroyed, all things reborn! The Promised Ark has come… the Promised Ark has come!”

Whatever Duncan had been about to say was instantly choked off.

Just what kind of serious problem did this cultist have in his head?!

Chapter 187: Preaching the End

The Subspace believer who had just awakened fell into a strange ecstasy after learning that he was on the Vanished. He raised his hands and shouted wildly, the words so jumbled no one could understand them. His crazed runaway state even scared Alice, who stumbled back two steps—she only just managed to grab her head in time so it wouldn't fall off.

"This batch of local specialty is terrifying!" Miss Doll stared wide?eyed as she hid behind Duncan. "What's wrong with him?"

How was Duncan supposed to know? He hadn't even finished asking his own questions!

Then the other two Enders woke up one after another. Once they understood where they were, they also fell into the same sort of ecstasy as the first, screaming and raving, shouting things like "the Promised Ark" and "the gate of Subspace." No matter what Duncan and Alice said beside them, they were completely unable to communicate.

By this point, Duncan had more or less guessed why these Enders had gone into such a frenzy.

They were fanatics chasing after Subspace, and the Vanished was a ghost ship that had returned from Subspace. In the eyes of these madmen… did the Vanished count as some kind of "miracle"?

Were they crazed believers who had seen a miracle?

But their feverish excitement still seemed a bit too much.

The three cultists clung together, crying and laughing and shouting at the same time. They praised the greatness of Subspace while shouting the name of the Vanished. Now and then they even let out sounds from their throats that no human should be able to make. Their layered, trembling cries really did sound like roars echoing from Subspace itself. In the end they even knelt on the deck all at once and began kissing the deck of the Vanished!

That final act finally angered Alice, who had just been watching the spectacle from the side. Miss Doll's eyes went round. She ran over, grabbed a mop, and brought it down on one cultist's head: "I just washed this deck!"

Before Alice even finished shouting, two buckets and several mops nearby came rolling and hopping over as well, laying into the crazed cultists with a flurry of blows. The fanatics' wild, unhinged cries, Alice's scolding, and the clatter of buckets and mops all mixed together, and the Vanished, which was usually especially quiet most of the time, suddenly became noisy and chaotic.

Duncan stared, dumbfounded. The scene of "the cursed Doll and her lackeys beating up intruders" shocked him deeply. His first reaction was to wonder when this doll had gotten so close with everything on the deck. Only after that did he hurry forward to stop the farce: "Stop!"

The buckets and mops stopped at once. Alice still couldn't help snapping the mop across one Ender's head again, then gave him a kick for good measure before stomping away, muttering resentfully, "I just washed the deck, and they went and licked it all over…"

"I also think what they did was pretty disgusting, but this is a bit much…" Duncan gave the doll a helpless look, then turned to the cultists who had just been beaten soundly. "Have you calmed down yet?"

The Enders lay on the deck. Despite the beating they had just taken, they showed no sign of weakness or fear. Instead they were still full of energy,

their faces twisted into creepy smiles. Their seemingly thin, bony bodies had an astonishing tolerance for pain, as if they had already thrown away the normal pain senses of human beings.

After hearing Duncan's words, one Preacher slowly turned his head. He looked into Duncan's eyes, and his muddied gaze took a long time to focus. Then a chilling laugh spilled out of his mouth: "Ha, haha… gatekeeper of the Promised Land, ghost at the helm, navigator of the Ark! I can see… I can see your heart! How pathetic… you have received this supreme blessing, yet you refuse His grace… You were qualified to step into the Promised Land, yet you turned it down! You… are dull!"

Duncan frowned slightly.

Alice immediately leaned in from behind him: "Captain, should I beat him up again?"

The buckets and mops beside her hopped closer at once, swaying behind Alice.

Like lackeys, and the lackeys of lackeys.

"Go wait quietly over there for a bit," Duncan waved his hand. He stared at the Ender who was still letting out strange laughs at him, his face expressionless. "From the sound of it, you know quite a lot about this 'ghost captain' of yours."

"Subspace whispers your name… whispers your dull refusal…" The cultist grinned. The blood from the beating trickled from the corner of his mouth and crawled along his chin as if it had a life of its own, like tiny tentacles. "You had already been granted that supreme blessing, so why run away… Don't you know that Subspace is the eternal and final destination of all things? You had already reached the end… why turn back from that end?!"

Duncan simply used his gaze on this cultist, who might have lost his mind or might just be caught in pure fanaticism. His face stayed calm, but his heart was stirred.

These fanatics who followed Subspace really did know a few things. Their insane faith had not only given them eerie powers, it had also let them learn some secrets related to Subspace. What this man was saying… might actually contain a part of the truth.

Had Captain Duncan fled from Subspace? Had he rejected Subspace's divine blessing?

Could it be that when the Vanished first fell into Subspace back then, the real "Captain Duncan" had not gone completely mad like the outside world claimed? That the Vanished's return voyage from Subspace had actually been a successful escape? That "Captain Duncan" still had some sanity left back then?

When did he completely lose his mind? And when did he die?

Duncan suddenly thought of Goathead's attitude whenever Subspace came up—wary, resistant, and even faintly afraid.

That seemed to indirectly confirm the Ender's words. It confirmed that escape.

Then the Ender fell back into a hazy state. He started muttering things only he could understand, sometimes suddenly bursting into joyful laughter, sometimes slapping his own body. His two companions never really sobered up at all, lost from beginning to end in a disturbing mental chaos.

These followers of Subspace were even more insane than the Suntists Duncan had seen, and even further from the normal sanity of the mortal world. They seemed to be in a constant state of mental unrest, their thoughts drifting between the mortal world and Subspace. Unless someone was

talking to them or they were carrying out a specific task, they could not think or communicate normally.

Was it because they had been affected by Subspace? Or had they shattered their own reason on purpose, using this method to embrace Subspace of their own will?

What puzzled Duncan even more was this—how did such crazy, bizarre cultists, whose very appearance had changed, move around the city?state in their daily lives?

With madmen like these, they wouldn't even have time to hide. They would be surrounded and riddled with bullets by the Guardians' Steam Walkers within five steps of walking down the street!

After a while longer, seeing that the Enders still showed no sign of coming to their senses, Duncan had to take the initiative again: "Why did you attack Shirley?"

The three cultists reacted. One of them lifted his head in a daze, his body swaying left and right. "Attack? Attack who?"

"What you just did." Duncan's voice was cold and hard, his face like water. "You attacked a girl with a Abyssal Hound—why did you attack her?"

"Attack… oh, attack…" The dazed cultist suddenly bared his teeth and shouted loudly: "We were only putting everything back on the right track, so that the correct history can arrive smoothly! A loophole, a flaw, a little hidden danger… the hidden danger must be removed… She should have died in the correct history. She shouldn't have survived! As long as she lives… the loopholes will keep appearing…"

"The correct history?" Duncan's eyes changed slightly as he listened to the cultist's crazed ravings. He caught the key information at once and reacted instantly. "Pland's timeline went wrong—was that your doing?!"

“Went wrong? There’s nothing wrong, nothing wrong at all… We are only putting everything back on the right track!” The madman lifted his face, his eyes filled with martyr?like fervor. “The whole world should return to the right track! Doom was delayed for so many years. Everyone defied Subspace’s gift and the fate that should have come! We are correcting history onto its proper path!”

“Correcting history onto its proper path!” The other two Enders beside him seemed infected and also began shouting praises in a frenzy. After shouting, one of them even stood up, raised both hands high, and proclaimed some kind of truth: “Only by returning to the proper track can there be rebirth after total annihilation! Subspace will devour everything, and Subspace will reshape everything! The fire has gone out, the embers can hardly burn… only by lighting a second bonfire can the world continue to exist within that grace!”

Chapter 188: The Madmen

The clues finally seemed to line up.

History in Pland bore the marks of corruption. In the small cathedral of the Sixth District there was a warped, sealed boundary in time and space. On the statue of the storm Goddess, a strange Subspace fissure lay hidden. And Subspace… could Corrupt everything except Subspace itself.

Shirley was one of the few who still remembered that great fire from years ago. When the blaze broke out, she should have died like everyone else, yet somehow she fused with a Abyssal Hound and survived. And when everyone else's understanding was warped by the corruption of history, she still kept her memories of that fire.

Now, a group of Enders had attacked Shirley. These fanatics who worshipped Subspace were deranged, their words absurd, yet every sentence circled around "correct history" and "loopholes".

Duncan certainly did not believe any of their ridiculous "truths". Whatever they called "correct history", he took as the opposite. But one point was obvious – these cultists were tied to the historical distortions in the city-state of Pland. The Subspace power behind them was the true culprit. And people like Shirley, who still remembered that fire from back then, were mortal enemies in the eyes of these madmen who wanted to Corrupt the Mortal Realm with a false history.

But not every question had been answered.

How had these madmen suddenly discovered Shirley, this “loophole”? What was the connection between historical corruption and the “Black Sun”? The Black Sun did not have the power to Corrupt history, so what role did that “Sun god” really play in all this? And most important of all…

Was Nina, the suspected vessel of a Sun fragment, going to be marked by these cultists too?

Duncan stared coldly at the three crazed Enders and lifted a finger. A tuft of ghostly green flame suddenly ignited on one of them. The fire scorched the cultist’s body, which could almost be treated as an “supernatural item”. He let out a sharp scream and curled up on the deck, and the other Enders instantly fell silent.

“Fire… profane fire…” A cultist’s eyes bulged. Even as a crazed Subspace follower who felt no fear of pain, he still showed terror when he saw that green flame. “Profane, profane… such a profane thing!”

“If you don’t want to be burned alive, keep cooperating with my questions.” Duncan let flames bloom all across the deck. They wove into a net of fire that trapped the three cultists, scorching both mind and flesh. “Tell me – how exactly do you Corrupt history? Did you start from the Sixth District?”

“We are putting history back on its proper track!” Even under the threat of the ghostly flames, the Enders did not forget their lines. One of them craned his neck and shouted, “The Sixth District… the Sixth District was only a failed attempt, but that doesn’t matter, it doesn’t matter…”

The Sixth District was only a failed attempt?

Duncan frowned at once. The man had not answered honestly, yet he had still let slip something vital.

First, that fire back then really was the work of these Subspace followers, and not simply a blaze caused by the appearance of a Sun fragment as he

had first assumed. Second, their attempt to Corrupt history seemed not to have fully succeeded – the great fire eleven years ago had not produced the result they wanted.

Then another key year suddenly surfaced in his mind – 1885.

That was the number Vanna had found under the small cathedral. It pointed to the year when the nun of that small cathedral died in battle, and, in theory, to the time when that cathedral had first been invaded by Subspace power.

The great fire eleven years ago, however, broke out in 1889, the fourth year after that nun fell.

In other words, it was four years after the small cathedral was invaded that the Enders started the fire of 1889 – and they called that fire a “failed attempt”.

A timeline slowly came into focus before Duncan’s eyes.

“You actually failed twice.” Duncan’s face was as calm and dark as still water as he fixed his gaze on the Ender writhing in the ghostly flames. “In 1885, you invaded a small cathedral and tried to use it as the origin point to spread your corruption of history. But a nun destroyed your plan with her life, sealing that year’s ‘invasion’ and her own ‘death’ inside the underground sanctum.

“Four years later, in 1889, you carried out your second plan. You started a great fire in the Sixth District where that small cathedral stood, hoping to overwrite the Mortal Realm with a ‘city-state consumed by fire’ History Branch. But you failed again. An unknown power erased all traces of that fire before it could keep burning…

“After that, you lay low in the city-state up to today, looking for chances to continue the plan, until you found Shirley, this loophole. You decided the

failure back then was tied to her survival, so you wanted to get rid of this ‘hidden danger’ first?”

The ghostly flames burned bright. The Ender curled up in the fire. Even his pain-hardened flesh struggled to endure this agony that burned directly at his soul. Yet the madman still showed no intention of answering. Instead, he slowly split his mouth into a grin and looked at Duncan with a chilling smile.

“You don’t need to answer. I can see it in your eyes. You are mocking and furious, which means I am right.” Duncan ignored the other man’s taunt and went on in an even voice. “Next I have another question… What link do you have with that ‘Black Sun’? The fire of 1889 was triggered by a Sun fragment… Did you arrange that fragment?”

The Ender remained silent.

Duncan spread the flames to the other two men and watched them curl and twitch in the fire, but he still did not get a single word in reply.

“If you refuse to speak, I can only guess.” Duncan sighed and waved his hand, dispersing the flames. He had already realized that simple “pain” meant nothing to these fanatics who embraced Subspace. Their bodies and minds had long since mutated beyond human. “I guess you have some level of cooperation with those Sun believers… No, perhaps it is a deal with the ‘Sun spawn’ behind those believers. You help those Sun spawn revive their ‘lord’, and the method of revival… is to summon the Sun from ‘history’ itself?”

He glanced at the cultists who still kept silent, then continued, “In the early years of the New City-State Calendar, there was once a city-state known to the world only by name, Wilheim. The last message it left to the world was this: ‘The Black Sun descended from history.’ So this is not the first time you have done this, is it? You summoned the Sun that should already have

gone out, dragged it out of history. That summoning process itself is the greatest corruption of history, isn't it?"

As all the scattered clues suddenly fit together, all the threads slowly linked into one. Things that had once been incomprehensible, even unbelievable, turned into facts he could now imagine. Duncan's imagination and memory ran at full speed. The known, the unknown, and the knowable slowly merged into a clear path in his mind.

Of course, many things still could not be explained. For example, how these Enders had even gotten mixed up with the Sun believers. What method they used to summon the Sun from history. Whether the ordinary Suntists and priests knew any of these secrets from the higher levels. He still had no answers.

Even much of what he had just pieced together was only speculation. Without an admission from the Enders before him, he lacked key proof.

The spirit-form flames on the deck slowly drew back, until only a ring of fire remained around the three cultists. Duncan stood before that wall of flame, looking down at the "preachers" with a blank face.

"You Enders who slipped into the city-state aren't just the three of you, are you?

"Where are the others hiding? What do you plan to do next? Keep erasing the 'loopholes' you talk about? Or wait for a chance to unleash an even greater corruption?

"Still refusing to answer?"

As Duncan threw out question after question, one of the cultists finally moved.

The scrawny fanatic slowly pulled at the corners of his mouth and lifted his head to look at Duncan. His voice was hoarse and muddy. "We did not hide

in your so-called city-state… We hide in this cursed, twisted history that should have ended long ago… Once it began, it will not end… What the Flamebearer could not do, you cannot do either, ‘Captain Mister’…”

The cultist’s grin grew wider, his smile chilling to the bone. His voice sank low, carrying both temptation and cold. “I just saw it. Your humanity is so dazzling. Where did you pick it up?”

Duncan’s gaze shifted at once. He took a step forward, his tone heavy and stern. “What do you mean?”

“…Wish you a pleasant day, Captain Mister.” The preacher suddenly seemed to turn into someone else. The crazed believer became a polite citizen. He slowly pushed himself up and sat hunched on the deck, yet his eyes seemed to look past Duncan as they roamed over the vast, silent Vanished. “Ah… the promised land, the Promised Ark…”

Chapter 189: Alice’s Test

After that, Duncan got no more useful information from the Enders.

They just sat silently on the deck, breathing in the sea breeze of the Boundless Sea as if savoring every second. To Duncan’s questions they either answered with an empty, indifferent gaze, or with mad, twisted laughter.

But the last words they had spoken were already burned deep into Duncan’s mind.

These fanatics who followed Subspace, whose minds were broken and whose sanity score was probably already in the negatives, seemed to have gained knowledge that should never have existed at all through their crazed faith – truths that in theory had never leaked out.

They had “seen” that “Captain Duncan” carried an anomalous “humanity” inside, and that this “humanity” had been “picked up”. What did that even mean? Could they really tell that the soul inside this body was no longer the original owner’s?!

And these cultists had also said they were not hiding in the city-state… but in history cursed by the curse. What did that mean? Were these mad Enders not in normal space-time most of the time, and that was why they could avoid the city-state Guardians even while acting so bizarrely?

Duncan silently turned his gaze on the Enders who were grinning strangely. Thoughts surged in his heart, and at the same time he watched over the state of the entire ship, sensing whether there were any changes in the Vanished.

Goathead was still dutifully steering in the captain’s cabin, apparently paying no attention to what was happening on deck.

Every part of the Vanished was operating as usual. The words of the Enders had no effect on the ship.

Alice sat hugging her own head on a big wooden barrel nearby, idly tidying her hair. The doll’s brain had long since failed to keep up with the conversation between the captain and the cultists, so she had wandered off early.

After who knew how long, Duncan finally let out a quiet breath.

He had spent a bit too long on these cultists, to the point that he could almost feel himself being affected by their mad babble.

He had already gotten plenty of useful information out of them, and it did not look like there would be any more. There was no need to keep bothering to care about these madmen.

Just as his expression shifted, one Ender suddenly lifted his head. In his muddled eyes, the empty, illusory sails of the Vanished were reflected. He mumbled like in a dream, “Is it time to get off the ship?”

“There was never a place for you on this ship,” Duncan said flatly. “But before I throw you overboard, you can still be of some use.”

All three Enders raised their heads and slowly pulled their mouths into strange smiles.

Although they had been wildly ecstatic when they first came aboard, even going so far as to kiss the deck, now, hearing Duncan’s words, they showed no sign of disappointment or fear.

At first, Duncan had thought they would at least struggle a little, try to force their way into staying on this ship, even find a way to use it to reach the

“promised land” of Subspace they yearned for. But there was nothing like that. Only a strange numbness filled their eyes.

It was as if, in some unseen moment, most of their personality and memories had slipped out of these bodies, or as if they had suddenly heard some far-off “calling” and calmly accepted their fate.

Duncan frowned, not bothering to guess what these already-crazed cultists were thinking. Instead he turned his head toward the doll staring into space not far away and said, “Alice, come here.”

The doll reacted at once. She deftly picked up her head, stuck it back onto her neck, hopped down from the barrel, and trotted over to Duncan. “Captain, you called me?”

“…Can you stop pulling your head off all the time?” Duncan grumbled with a frown. “Your joints aren’t that sturdy to begin with, and every time you take it off your intelligence seems to drop with it.” He shook his head, then pointed at the three cultists. “I’m going to have you run a little test.”

“A test?” Alice blinked. “What kind of test?”

“To see whether that uncontrollable ‘Guillotine’ ability of yours is still there.” Duncan raised an eyebrow. “Don’t tell me you’ve already forgotten about it.”

“I did forget!” Alice nodded with complete confidence. “I only just remembered when you brought it up!”

She paid no attention to the subtle shift in Duncan’s expression and turned to the “Enders”, waving at them. “Hello, I forgot to introduce myself just now. I’m Alice, the ship’s… cook?”

“You should tell them your other identity,” Duncan said casually. He spoke to Alice, but his gaze rested on the cultists. “Anomaly 099.”

The eyes of the three Enders finally changed. One of them could not help but glance at Alice, and a sudden seriousness appeared in his expression.

“I thought you were really numb enough to be beyond fear of life and death.” Duncan noted the change but kept his face calm. “In that case, I hope you madmen who fear not even Subspace will enjoy what comes next. What I need you to do is simple: stay near Alice, and then either survive… or die by decapitation.”

Alice listened at his side, then leaned in to mutter, “Captain, when you say things like that you really sound like a villain…”

Duncan gave the doll a speechless look. “…Whose side are you on, exactly?”

“Death means nothing to us…” While Duncan and Alice whispered, one Ender finally spoke up. He glanced at Alice and even took a step forward, a hint of mockery in his eyes. “It is only another pause in this long journey. You dull-witted one who rejected Subspace’s grace, obsessed with the veils of the Mortal Realm, you will never know the Truth beyond life and death…”

Duncan hurriedly tugged Alice’s arm. “Hear that? That’s what a villain sounds like…”

Alice nodded. “Oh.”

Then Duncan ignored the reactions of the Enders. He looked up at the night sky where the World’s Wound hung high and suddenly asked, “How long have they been aboard?”

“Several hours at least, right?” Alice thought for a moment. “My sense of time is pretty accurate!”

“Several hours… which means the check and trigger time for Guillotine has already passed at least once.” Duncan grew thoughtful. His gaze fell on the

doll in front of him while his mind recalled the descriptions of Anomaly 099's properties. "But that's still not enough to be sure. We'll wait a bit longer, then run the next round of tests."

"Next round of tests?" Alice blinked in confusion. "How are we testing it?"

"Right now we can roughly say your Guillotine ability has not triggered, but we still can't tell whether that is because of the Vanished or because of me." As Duncan spoke, his eyes swept over the Enders, as if he was making very sure their heads were still attached. "After a few more hours, once we are sure at least one full check-and-trigger cycle of your ability has passed, I want you and these 'preachers' to leave the Vanished for a while."

"Leave the Vanished for a while?" Alice froze. "Go where?"

She lifted her head and looked past the rail. All she saw was endless ocean. The wind and waves were calm; the whole sea was soaked in the pale glow of the World's Wound, making it look almost like a boundless snowfield. On that endless sea, there was nowhere to set foot.

Duncan thought for a moment.

Now he had found "materials" for Alice's test, but to keep the process strict he also needed a "testing ground" where he could rule out his own interference. That test site could not be on crowded land, and it had to be outside the Vanished. There really were not many choices.

"We have a few lifeboats in good shape. I'll lower one into the water and temporarily cut its connection with the Vanished." Duncan looked into Alice's eyes. "You will drift on the sea for a while. I'll keep the main ship nearby and I won't abandon you."

The doll listened to the captain's plan and instantly shrank her neck. "Float on the sea again?! I'm still traumatized! And the visibility on the sea at

night is so bad. What if you lose me? What if a gust of wind and waves carries the little boat away? What if the boat capsizes…”

Duncan cut off this embarrassing doll before she could finish. “Stop, stop, there won’t be that many ‘what ifs’. I’ll have AI circling above you to keep watch. And besides, you’re afraid you can’t get back to the ship? Last time you rode the waves back on nothing but a coffin lid. Even eight cannonballs couldn’t keep you down. This time you at least have two proper oars.”

Alice’s muttering was choked off, but only for a moment. She glanced worriedly at the sea nearby, then at the half-human, half-ghost, mindless Subspace believers, and grabbed Duncan’s sleeve hard. “Captain, you promised. You must not lose me later!”

Duncan: “…”

He really felt that the longer he kept this doll on board, the more useless she became. She was worse now than when she had been riding the waves of the Boundless Sea. Back then, at least, she had a bit of foolish courage…

Chapter 190: As If Yesterday Vanished

World’s Wound hung high in the night sky. A cold wind blew over the Boundless Sea. Fine waves rose and fell softly around them, and the little boat rocked like a dream that had not yet fully woken before dawn.

But Alice did not really know what it meant to “dream”. She had slept for a very, very long time, yet she had never truly dreamed the way humans did. She guessed that dreaming should be a state something like this.

She floated in a vast, vast place, and her thoughts drifted with it.

She lifted her head. In the distance there was only the sea. The far-off lights of the Vanished were like tiny candle flames floating on the surface of the water. It even gave her the feeling that the whole world had disappeared, leaving only herself, the little boat beneath her, and the endless Boundless Sea.

Oh, and the three Enders trussed up across from her.

Miss Doll drew back her gaze from the distance and looked curiously at the cultists tied up in front of her.

They were humans, the very bad kind. Alice did not know many humans, but she knew there were good ones and bad ones. Good people did very good things. Captain Duncan would praise them and sometimes even help them. Bad people did very bad things. Captain Duncan would despise them

and sometimes report them. The three in front of her… were the kind the captain disliked the most.

They believed in Subspace and followed a vicious creed. For the sake of some great cause they had made up, they could kill anyone, even attack a pitiful young lady who only had a dog for company. If a city-state Guardian found them, the Guardian would shoot them to death in the street without hesitation. If sailors at sea found them, they would hang them from the mast. Even a vicious pirate, if he found them, would stuff these madmen into a wooden crate and throw them into the sea, using them as an offering to beg the Storm Goddess for protection.

But now they were tied up and sitting quietly. There was no sign of any mad urge to run wild. Alice could still remember how frightening they had looked when they first came aboard, all worked up as if they had taken the wrong medicine.

Now, as time passed, these Enders grew more and more obedient.

“Are you scared?”

After holding it in for a long time, Alice finally could not help speaking. She felt very uncomfortable out here. She knew this was a “safety test” she had to go through so she could move around in the human city-states, but drifting on the Boundless Sea still made her feel restless and uneasy.

One of the Enders answered the doll’s voice. His skull-like, skinny head slowly lifted, and he stared into Alice’s eyes: “Stupid filth, a clumsy shell… your soul is pale and hollow. Even Subspace would not take you…”

Alice froze for a moment. A few seconds later she reacted: “Hey, why are you insulting me?!”

The Enders opposite her only let out a string of hoarse, ugly laughter. Faced with Anomaly 099, which terrified the world, they did not seem afraid at

all.

Or perhaps, just as they claimed, they had long since risen above the idea of life and death and no longer cared when death came in the Mortal Realm.

Alice could only sulk by herself, but after a while she shook her head and said: “I’m not angry anymore.”

Another Ender looked up at her once, but said nothing.

Alice kept talking to herself: “I shouldn’t be angry. You’re the ones who get to complain a bit. After all, you’re the ones tied up right now, not me, and you’re the ones doing this head-falling-off test, not me. The captain said that when the wind is fair you can’t get too pleased with yourself, because if the waves get big the ship will overturn, and if people act too wild they’ll die… And since you’ve already fallen this low, my lordly self can be generous and allow you to run your mouths a little.”

The Enders sat silently in the boat, listening to the doll ramble on, as if they had completely shut out her voice. But after a while, Alice still noticed they had some “little movements”—

They were secretly studying one another’s heads, moving their own necks from time to time, and now and then sneaking a careful glance her way, their eyes full of doubt.

Alice thought about it carefully and felt they were probably wondering why their heads were still on their necks.

These cultists clearly knew the information about Anomaly 099. They might truly not fear death, but they still felt curiosity. After staying so close to Anomaly 099 for so long, they found it hard to understand why they were still alive.

“Actually, I am a little scared,” Alice suddenly said. “I’m afraid your heads will suddenly fall off. The captain said I have the ability to decapitate

people. When I first heard that, it scared me a lot. Humans aren't like me. When a human's head falls off, it can't be put back on…"

A sudden flapping of wings came from above. Alice looked curiously toward the sound and saw the dove AI suddenly fly off into the distance. After a short while, it flew back from the direction of the Vanished, emerald flame rising from its body.

AI circled twice over the sea near the little boat. Ghostly green flame surged up, and in the great whirlpool of fire an ornate wooden chest appeared out of nowhere, then fell with a splash into the sea beside them.

"My box!" Alice's eyes widened at once and she cried out in surprise. At once the words "swept out the door" popped into her mind, and her head almost fell off her neck. But then she noticed there seemed to be a note stuck to the chest. She quickly paddled twice with the oar at hand, drew close, and took the note off. On it was a single line of words:

"The Guillotine ability might also be connected to your wooden chest, so I'm sending it for testing along with you. Also: you are definitely overthinking that I'm kicking you off the ship again—stop it. Come back as soon as you finish the test."

Alice held up the note and turned it over, reading it several times, but did not understand it.

She could not read…

But soon she saw something else on the back of the note. It was a rough little sketch, showing her rowing the boat back to the Vanished, with a smiling face drawn at the end.

Miss Doll understood at once. No matter what was written on the front, the captain clearly did not mean to drive her away.

Relieved, she carefully put the note away, then casually fished the chest out of the sea and, with a bang, tossed the rather heavy box onto the little boat with one hand. Only then did she look up at the cultists across from her: “Are you hungry?”

The preachers did not answer. She did not mind and just muttered to herself: “The captain said you all deserve to die, but he also said that if you really get through the test without dying, he won’t kill you. He’ll send you back to the city-state to be used for… what was it again…”

Miss Doll stalled, trying hard to remember. At last she recalled what the captain had told her before: “Oh, to show how much a warm-hearted citizen cares about the safety of the city-state… He said you were worth at least seven bicycles. What is a bicycle?”

“Subspace will grant us food and warmth… Subspace will grant us peace… Subspace will bestow its divine blessing on all the dead, after all the Ends arrive as promised…”

One Ender began to mutter in a muffled voice. It sounded a little like an answer to Alice’s rambling and a little like some blasphemous prayer. “We walk within the End, cast off this cursed flesh, and our minds will pass over that wall and open their eyes again in the New World…”

“Huh?” Alice listened in total confusion. “What are you mumbling about?”

The Enders no longer answered her and did not respond again after that.

From then until dawn, they only sat there with their heads lowered, muttering to themselves. They mumbled about Subspace, about the End of some long river of time, about a Doomsday that was destined to come and ought to come. On the waves that rose and fell with the wind, aside from the soft slap of water against the hull, there was only the ceaseless muttering of these madmen.

It was the kind of atmosphere that would make an ordinary person's skin crawl. The content of their prayer could make anyone with a weak will fall under the curse, tainted and entangled by Shadows from the deep layers of the world. Yet Alice only felt that it was noisy.

She had the little note the captain wrote, so she no longer feared this drift. Now she was only bored out of her mind.

But that boring time finally ended.

A thread of morning light suddenly appeared over the distant sea. In the pale dawn, World's Wound in the sky quickly faded and thinned, and the Sun, bound by double layers of runes, slowly rose out of the sea and leaped into the sky.

It was dawn.

Alice had not decapitated anyone.

Miss Doll happily watched the sunrise. She stood up from beside the chest, turned her head to the cultists, and said: "Hey! It's dawn! You're still alive! We can go back now!"

However, the three Enders did not answer her. They still hunched in the boat with their heads lowered, whispering softly. In the brief darkness before the sunlight spilled into the boat, they called on Subspace for "attention" one last time.

Only when Alice called out again did one of them finally raise his head. This cultist glanced at the sunlight slowly spreading toward them, looking a little dazed, but slowly a strange smile spread over his face.

"Oh, our day is over again…" the madman sighed softly. Then he slowly turned his head and looked into Alice's perfect, gem-carved eyes. His smile held a twisted mix of madness and calm. "Doll, we will meet again one day."

“Huh?” Alice was stunned. “What do you mean by that? It’s not like you can just run away into thin air…”

The sunlight spread over them.

The three Enders vanished without a sound in the morning glow, like yesterday’s fading phantoms.

“No way you could…” Alice finished half the sentence out of habit, then stared wide-eyed. “You really did run away?!”

Chapter 191: Nonlinear Existence and Preparations to Go to the City-State

The doll once again rode the waves back to the Vanished, and she looked a little shaken. After listening to the embarrassed doll's jumbled account, Duncan also stared in shock.

"They disappeared? Vanished into thin air right in front of you?" Duncan stared, dumbfounded, at Alice, then looked toward the lifeboat that the winch had just hoisted to the ship's side. The ropes they had used to tie up the Enders still lay on the little boat, but the cultists who had been bound by them were long gone.

"Yeah, yeah! They were just gone in an instant! Not even a sound!" Alice waved her hands as she explained her strange experience to Duncan. "The moment the sunlight fell on them, they disappeared, as if they had never existed at all…"

"They disappeared without a sound the moment the sunlight fell on them…" Duncan frowned. He had imagined countless ways those Enders might escape or resist, but he had never thought they would simply vanish like that. It made many of his preparations useless. "If they had just jumped into the sea, I could still understand it—at least that counts as soluble in water. But soluble in sunlight? What kind of principle is that… Could it be related to the Sun? Does the Sun's suppressive power keep them from remaining in the Mortal Realm?"

“I don’t know.” Alice stared wide-eyed, sounding perfectly confident.

“I wasn’t asking you,” Duncan gave the doll a look. “Before they disappeared, did anything seem off? What were they saying? Did they perform some strange ritual?”

“They… just kept muttering, talking about Subspace, some promised land, some destined End and rebirth and cycles,” Alice rubbed her head, then suddenly remembered. “Oh, right! One of the cultists also said, ‘Our day is over again.’…”

“Their ‘day’ is over again?” Duncan’s brow creased at once, and for some reason he thought of what one Ender had told him before—

They hid within history that had fallen under the curse.

Some ridiculous guesses rose in his mind, but when he thought about how absurd this world already was, even the wildest things did not seem all that impossible.

“Captain?” Alice saw that Duncan had been frowning and thinking for a long time without answering her. At last she could not help speaking up: “What did you think of? You…”

“Nothing,” Duncan shook his head. It sounded half like he was talking to himself, half like a soft sigh. “I just suddenly had a crazy thought. Those so-called Enders… I’m afraid they might be a kind of Nonlinear Existence…”

“Nonlinear Existence?” Alice froze. With her limited brain and knowledge, she could not keep up with the captain’s train of thought. “What does that mean?”

“…You’d better not ask. With your level of intelligence, it would be hard to explain it clearly,” Duncan glanced at Alice, hesitated for two seconds, then still shook his head. “But I suddenly understood why the book Morris gave

me said that the Enders are the most mysterious and the hardest cultists to find and capture… It's too absurd."

Too absurd—Duncan repeated in his heart.

They hid within an abnormal flow of history, themselves a form of Nonlinear Existence, shuttling through the Mortal Realm with the cycle of day and night. Unless they were killed on the spot, you could never detain today a Ender you had caught yesterday—that was the staggering truth he had deduced from the clues so far.

By comparison, the Suntists—though just as cruel and dark, and mostly made up of rabble—suddenly seemed much more ordinary and almost familiar. They also had the strange trait of constantly transforming out of ordinary people under the influence of the creeping Sun Wheel, but at least they were not twisted to this degree.

Still, that raised another question. If the Enders really were a kind of Nonlinear Existence as he guessed, then how had they ended up like this? How could ordinary humans separate themselves from the normal time stream and become some sort of "slice creature" that existed discontinuously in time?

Was it just because they followed Subspace… and so received Subspace's mad, deranged "divine blessing"?

"Captain, you're staring off again…"

Alice's voice sounded again. The doll was looking at Duncan with a hint of worry.

"I'm fine." Duncan let out a soft breath and packed away those messy thoughts. He felt it was too early to hold a mental storm over this. After all, this was his first real contact with these Subspace believers, and it was no use making the wildest guesses too soon.

He turned his gaze back to Alice.

“You saw the note I gave you, right?” he asked casually.

“I did!” Alice nodded at once, happy. “When I first saw the box I was scared. I thought you were telling me not to come back. Then I saw the note and felt better… I couldn’t read the words on it, but I understood the picture you drew…”

Duncan’s mouth twitched. The sudden impulse he’d had after writing that note had really come in handy. This doll really was illiterate. “…So you really can’t read.”

“I can’t read at all!” Alice said with her usual confidence. “I lay in the box for so many years. It’s already amazing that I picked up some common sense just by listening. How could I have learned to recognize words too…”

Duncan was silent.

“Captain, what are you thinking about?”

“I suddenly wondered… whether it would work to hold a tutoring class on the Vanished or in the antique shop,” Duncan sighed. “Counting you, I already know two illiterates—and if I add the dog, that makes three. That’s enough to form a study group.”

Alice thought for a bit. “What is a tutoring class? And what is a study group?”

“…I’ll explain later,” Duncan waved a hand, and his expression grew a little more serious. “Let’s talk about the ‘test’ first. Those three cultists were all normal before they vanished, right? Even after you sent the chest over, they weren’t affected in any way?”

“Of course they were normal. Their heads were still on their necks. I saw it very clearly.”

Duncan curled his fingers under his chin and looked at Alice, deep in thought.

Though the traits of the Enders were bizarre, they definitely did not have the power or “supernatural resistance” of the Saint. After all, Shirley had smashed three of them to death just by swinging the dog at them. That proved their flesh-and-blood bodies were still “normal material” that could be destroyed. At most, their tolerance for pain was far beyond that of ordinary people.

And now those three Enders had stayed beside Alice for so long without being affected at all. In other words… had the effect of Guillotine really disappeared?

Watching Duncan’s changing expression, even Alice finally began to catch on. She cautiously edged closer, tilted her face up, a faint hope on her features: “Captain… did I pass my ‘test’? Can you take me to the city-state now?”

“The test… should be passed. The strange traits of those Enders still make me uneasy, but judging from the result…” Duncan spoke slowly, still thinking and weighing things, but in the end he nodded. “All right, the test really is passed. It looks like your Guillotine ability is under control now.”

He paused there, and before Alice could start celebrating, he added: “I’ll take you to a city-state, but not right away. You lack a lot of basic knowledge about the human world, and you also have parts that are easy to give away, like your fingers and the joints of your wrists. For the first, you need a lot of extra lessons. For the second, we need some disguises.”

“Mm-hmm, I know, I know!” Alice nodded hard. She did not seem discouraged at all by the problems Duncan mentioned. Instead she looked even more motivated. “Mr. Goathead told me that too. He said the human world is very complicated, that even going out to buy vegetables has a pile

of rules. He said if I want to go to a human city-state, I definitely have to ‘catch up on my lessons’, and that if there’s anything I don’t understand I can ask…”

“Don’t ask him!!” Before Alice could finish, Duncan felt a jolt and quickly cut off this doll who spent all day thick as thieves with Goathead and looked about ready to grow crooked for good. “He’s even less human-shaped than you are, and you want to learn human society from him? Where is your brain?”

Alice looked completely innocent. “I don’t have one!”

Duncan almost choked on his own breath. He stared for a long time, then finally squeezed out: “You… I admit you have a point.”

“Hehe…”

“In short, don’t learn anything from that Goathead in the future. He can’t teach you anything good,” Duncan sighed. Every time he talked with this doll, he felt his nerves being tested, as if he were making a sanity check. “Later I’ll set aside time to cram some common knowledge into you and think about your disguise. For now, you’re done here. Go make dinner.”

“Oh, okay,” Alice nodded hard. Just as she was about to leave, she seemed to remember something, turned back, and looked at Duncan curiously. “Then what are you going to do, Captain?”

“I have some things to discuss with Goathead,” Duncan waved his hand, looking tired. “Things that don’t concern you.”

Alice nodded and turned toward the cabin, in a very good mood, walking with light yet proper steps.

Duncan watched Miss Doll’s back as she left and could not help thinking again—

When she neither spoke nor turned her head, she really was elegant.

It was just a pity she had a mouth…

Chapter 192: Promised Ark

The cabin was as it had always been. sunlight drifting in from the Boundless Sea poured through the porthole into the room, making the old items that had soaked up a century of time shine with bright reflections. The black Goathead sculpture sat quietly on one corner of the enchanted sea chart table, steering the Vanished's course.

On the surface of that ancient enchanted sea chart, thin mist rolled and billowed. Within the layered fog, the lines that marked the known sea routes were stretching straight ahead, extending toward a distant point.

At the end of that course lay the city-state of Pland. The flickering point of light that marked it had already appeared in the mist ahead and was slowly, almost imperceptibly, closing the distance with the Vanished.

The door opened, and Duncan's figure appeared in the doorway.

The Goathead sculpture stirred at once. Its wooden neck creaked as it turned its head toward the sound: "Ah, the great Captain has come to his loyal deputy's side! Has everything been going well? You have been busy since yesterday. Are you in a good mood today? The weather today is…"

"Stop, stop. You don't have to repeat the same greeting several times every day." Duncan raised his hand to cut him off before he could finish. Then his gaze stopped on Goathead's face for a moment, as if by accident.

Goathead was as always. No expression showed on its face, and its obsidian-carved eyes were still strangely cold. From the tabletop it fixed its gaze on this side, its look filled with an inhuman quality.

But there was no hint of danger, and nothing different from usual.

This thing seemed to have been obeying Duncan's orders in earnest. Duncan told it to focus on steering the ship, and it really only focused on steering the ship.

"Captain, you look worried?" Goathead's voice sounded, carrying that familiar flunky-like enthusiasm. "You seem to have brought back some prisoners… but they don't seem to be on the ship anymore?"

"They disappeared after the Sun rose," Duncan said calmly as he walked unhurriedly to the chart table and sat down. "They were a few Enders."

"Ah, Enders… such troublesome and dangerous fellows. They really are hard to catch. They always appear out of nowhere and then vanish just as strangely," Goathead immediately started babbling, just as Duncan knew he would. Once a topic opened up, this thing would spit out a whole string of nonsense, though that nonsense often hid useful information, so there was hardly any need to question it carefully. "But how did they provoke you? Those crazy preachers don't usually show themselves. Compared with the Suntists or the Annihilators, they are much more low-key and rare…"

"They attacked a human I was keeping an eye on, so I grabbed them on the way back and used them to test Alice's abilities," Duncan said casually while watching Goathead's reaction. "They also said a lot of mystical nonsense about Subspace… how much do you know about these cultists?"

"I would advise you not to pay too much attention to their mad 'preaching'," Goathead said at once. "Just calling Subspace's name too often can draw a dangerous gaze, let alone dealing with those madmen who follow Subspace. Of course, a Great Presence like you may not be affected by them, but listening to too much of it is never a good thing…"

Then it paused for a moment before speaking again: “Let me tell you, I don’t know that much about those madmen, and there aren’t many in this world who do. The Enders should count as the strangest group among all cultists. They are good at appearing and disappearing, their thoughts are broken and scattered, and unlike normal cults they don’t have large numbers of rabble at the bottom. There are far fewer of them, and there isn’t a single one you can talk to like a normal person…”

Goathead kept chattering, and the farther it went the more nonsense it piled up, but in that long-winded rambling Duncan still picked out some key pieces of information.

According to Goathead, the number of Enders was far lower than that of the other two cult forces that were also deadly threats to civilization, namely the Suntists and the Annihilators. Judging from records in the present world and their known activities, they might only number in the thousands, perhaps even less.

Ordinary cults had large numbers of ordinary people serving as the “believers at the bottom”. These rabble had no real power and lived normal social lives. Aside from their minds already being corrupted, they were basically no different from any other ordinary person. But the Enders had no such base layer. Whenever they appeared, they were all powerful “priests”.

No one knew how a heretic cult could operate and survive for so long without that sort of foundation, just as no one knew the exact process by which Suntists or Annihilators carried out their transformations among ordinary people.

In addition, although the word “preacher” sat right there in their name, they seemed to have almost no successful cases of actually “preaching”. Their sanity had long since evaporated, and their speech and logic were not like

those of normal people. Whenever they appeared, they would mutter and chant “truths” about Subspace, but anyone with a sound mind would not fall for their bewitching words. As for people with weak wills… they would already have been corrupted by Subspace into monsters before they could be tempted.

In other words, in theory the Enders could not increase their numbers by preaching at all.

And lastly, the Enders appeared and vanished like ghosts. They were very, very elusive.

Duncan had already experienced that himself.

Goathead claimed that it did not know much about the Enders, but the information it gave was anything but little.

“A bunch of preachers so deranged they can’t even ‘preach’ anymore…” Duncan rubbed his chin and muttered to himself. “Then where did the very first Enders come from?”

“Who knows?” Goathead’s neck creaked as it swayed. “Maybe they just grew straight out of Subspace…”

Duncan did not bother with this obvious piece of nonsense, a “Subspace joke” from Goathead. Likewise, he did not bring up his own “nonlinear guess” about the Enders.

He only thought to himself that if someone like him, who had just had his first contact with the Enders, could already come up with such a guess, then what about the Guardians and Bishops in the human city-states, those who had long fought against heretics? How much did they know about those Subspace believers? Did they have a more complete theory to explain the strangeness of those madmen?

“Captain, you seem very concerned about those Enders?” In the middle of the silence, Goathead’s voice suddenly broke the stillness of the room. “I rarely see you with such a serious look on your face…”

Duncan lifted his head and looked at Goathead in silence.

“Tell me, if the history of a city-state has been corrupted, can it still be saved?”

He suddenly asked.

His tone was calm and casual, as if he was just discussing some ordinary “academic guess” in his spare time.

Goathead froze for a moment, though its stiff face had never really had much expression to begin with. It took two or three seconds before it answered: “History being corrupted? Oh, that’s a high-level topic. It sounds like the kind of thing only Subspace could pull off…”

“Only Subspace could do that?” Duncan raised an eyebrow. “Why do you say that?”

“Besides something as dangerous as Subspace, where time and causality are a tangled mess to begin with, what else could casually Corrupt the history of a city-state?” Goathead said offhandedly. “Nothing in the mortal world has that kind of power… oh, if we are only talking about sheer power, there might be one thing that qualifies, but that thing is hanging up in the sky…”

Listening to Goathead’s muttering, Duncan felt his heart give a jolt.

Time and causality inside Subspace were chaotic?

This was the first time he had heard such a clear and direct piece of information about Subspace.

Along with this information, another memory rose up in his mind, of what the Frostholm Queen had once said to him in that illusory scene—

Do not Corrupt history.

He frowned and forced down the tangle of thoughts in his heart for the time being, letting his gaze fall back on Goathead. The latter at once noticed the Captain's gaze, stopped babbling, and quickly reacted: "Ah, no wonder you suddenly care about those Enders… could it be that they…"

"They probably pulled off something big," Duncan said in a low tone. "And it makes me a bit… uneasy."

He looked quietly into Goathead's eyes, and Goathead stared back at him without expression. It felt as if they were watching each other, yet there seemed to be no other form of exchange.

"City-states have their own Guardians, and those Flamebearers are always watching the flow of history," Goathead finally said. "No matter what trouble those Enders stir up, they can't threaten you. Even if they can Corrupt history, they can't Corrupt you or the Vanished…"

Duncan raised an eyebrow. "They can't Corrupt me or the Vanished?"

"…We returned from Subspace, Captain," Goathead said slowly. "Everything in the world can be corrupted—except Subspace itself. And we… have stayed in Subspace long enough."

Duncan frowned again. For some reason, some of the insane words the Enders had said suddenly surfaced in his mind.

After a short silence, he could not help but murmur under his breath: "Promised Ark…"

Chapter 193: “Captain”

Subspace could Corrupt everything except Subspace itself, even the Mortal Realm and the flow of years. Yet this seemed to be no problem for the Vanished.

Because in a sense, this ship was already a part of Subspace. In fact, even now its keel was still sailing through Subspace.

You could not drive someone with a sanity score of zero into madness, and you could not Corrupt the Vanished again after Subspace had already remade it completely.

Listening to Goathead’s words, Duncan showed a thoughtful look, but he did not stay lost in thought for long, because Goathead’s voice came again from the chart table: “Captain, you have begun to take an interest in matters inside the borders of civilization. Before this, you were always focused on sailing toward the outer frontier. Is there something in the city-states that has special meaning for you?”

Sailing toward the outer frontier?

Duncan’s heart stirred a little, but his face stayed calm. He only answered casually: “I am simply paying attention. I do not need a reason.”

“Ah, very well. You are the Captain, you have the final say,” Goathead replied at once. Then it fell silent for two seconds, as if hesitating or thinking, before speaking again in a low voice: “Then, just in case, I want to ask you a question.”

Duncan raised his eyebrows.

He heard its hoarse, low voice come from inside the wood carving: “Name?”

“Duncan Abnomar,” Duncan said with no expression, his fingers lightly interlaced. But this time, after speaking that name he suddenly smiled and asked in return: “To be honest, I’m curious. What would happen if I gave another name?”

This was the first time he had asked this question, and it was also his boldest boundary crossing so far. His life on this ship, his many contacts with Goathead, and his growing understanding of his own power and nature had finally led him to test this step.

Mutual testing and watching had built the most basic kind of tacit understanding between them. Duncan’s counter-question revealed a fact that both sides already knew deep down. After that question, Goathead fell into a long silence. It was a full minute before its low, hoarse voice sounded again in the captain’s cabin: “Then you should try not to tease me like that, Captain. The Vanished still needs you at the helm.”

Duncan laughed.

Just as he had thought, if Goathead had been “Captain Duncan’s” deputy for the past century, then its understanding of that ghost captain might even surpass the captain’s understanding of himself. And considering how many strange supernatural things existed in this world, how could a first mate who knew the captain so well fail to notice the captain’s changes or fail to think of the possible reasons?

No matter how careful a disguise was, it had flaws, and those flaws would only become more obvious as time went on. Yet no one had brought up this

flaw, which meant that this level of disguise was just right and also necessary.

The Vanished needed a captain, and that captain's name was "Duncan Abnomar". What lay behind that name was not important. Whether the captain himself was "real" was not important either. As long as there was someone qualified to hold the wheel, that was enough.

Duncan was only a little curious why it had to be him, and whether his having his own will now was actually an accident. By his general understanding of ghost ships, if a cursed ship had to keep "grabbing" people to be its captain, then the chosen person should in fact be under the curse's control. Yet he clearly was not bound by anything.

But he did not ask these questions, because Goathead's attitude was faintly reminding him:

Some things were fine as long as everyone knew them. There was no need to say them out loud.

Before he understood all the secrets behind the Vanished, this topic could end here.

"You still need your loyal first mate to serve you, and the Vanished still needs its great Captain to steer it personally. What do you think?" Goathead's voice came from the side, sounding a bit expectant, even earnest.

Duncan turned his head, fixing his gaze on those obsidian-carved eyes.

"Of course," he said with a smile.

Then he stood up and walked toward the door of the captain's cabin: "I'm going to leave for a while. Look after this ship."

Goathead had already returned to his usual flunky attitude, his tone cheerful: “Of course. Your loyal—well, you know the rest—will be here waiting for your return. I wish you a smooth…”

Duncan had already pushed the door open and walked out of the room, shutting the rest of Goathead’s words behind the door.

He stood on the aft deck and let out a light breath. A strange sense of ease rose in his heart. The morning sunlight was spilling over the sea, bathing the whole deck in a warm glow. The door that led to the captain’s cabin stood quietly before Duncan, and the letters on the frame—“Door of the Lost Ones”—shone in the sunlight.

He pressed down on the handle and gently pushed forward.

Inside the captain’s cabin, Goathead sensed that the Captain had temporarily left the Vanished.

It stayed silent. Everything in the room was silent. Even the whole ship was silent. But after a few minutes, a low creaking sound suddenly came from beneath the floor. Then some of the furnishings in the room began to sway slightly, making all kinds of faint noises.

Goathead’s voice then broke the silence, muttering to itself: “Oh, man… he isn’t mad, right… he shouldn’t be mad… damn, he really isn’t mad, right…”

The faint sounds in the room grew more obvious.

“I know, I know… It’s not like I’m the one who wants to ask for his name every few days! It’s for the safety of the voyage! If we suddenly fall back into Subspace, we should at least be prepared, right… Stop making noise, stop making noise, I’m still all mixed up here… Next time you can ask, how about that? If you can’t, then stop complaining… You all know I’m the only one on this whole ship with a mouth…

“That doll? Are you out of your minds? How would she know what’s going on… Wait, since when did you get so close to her? Aren’t you fighting all day… You feel guilty because you bullied her too much? Is that even a thing?

“All right, all right, scatter, scatter. Focus on the voyage. The Captain could come back at any time, and he might ask about our progress… Hey, anchor, can you learn how to paddle? Swing yourself a bit to provide some thrust. I’ve seen the propellers on those steamships… Fine, forget I said anything… Then how about those two lifeboats? You two can jump down and churn a bit? All right, forget that too…”

The sounds in the captain’s cabin slowly quieted down.

Goathead let out a silent sigh and went on controlling this huge ghost ship, steering it toward the city-state of Pland.

On the enchanted sea chart shrouded in mist, the flickering point that marked that city-state drew a little closer.

…

Zhou Ming pushed open the door of his studio apartment and stepped into the world he knew.

Outside the window, everything was still wrapped in fog. The world he knew still stretched only this short distance.

Everything in the room remained as it had been when he left. The bedding on the bed was a little messy. The book on the bedside table lay open. In the corner, the computer screen flickered faintly, and the notice “Network disconnected” kept popping up again and again in the lower right corner.

Zhou Ming let out a soft breath and walked at ease to the shelf at the far end of the room.

The miniature model of the Vanished still lay quietly in its cubby, exactly where he had placed it last time.

Zhou Ming picked up the lifelike “model” of the ghost ship and opened the door to the captain’s cabin again to glance inside.

The chart table was still empty. Goathead was nowhere to be seen.

Zhou Ming thought for a while, then put the Vanished back in its place. He turned to the desk, planning to sit down and rest, and to sort through the information he already had in this familiar and quiet setting, to straighten out his thoughts.

But suddenly, something on the desk caught his eye.

Strictly speaking, it was not some “thing”, but some strange… phenomenon.

He saw very, very tiny flames jumping on the empty surface of the desk. The small flames linked together like sparks, and under their weak, ghostly green light, some vague outlines appeared and faded in the air.

It was as if something was condensing on the desk, but the forming was too slow, stuck right at the point before taking shape.

Zhou Ming sat down in front of the desk and quietly watched those leaping flames and the scenes whose outlines were faintly taking shape within them. The ghostly green firelight shone on his face, and his slightly thin features gradually grew serious.

He recognized that some of the outlines drawn by the dancing flames were places he knew—that was certain districts of Pland!

He could even make out some details of the city-state’s coastline.

The fire was still burning, and Zhou Ming remembered that the order he had given that flame was to keep chasing and hunting those “things” that

carried black umbrellas.

Now it had almost spread to every corner of the city-state.

The prey… was everywhere!?

Zhou Ming’s brows slowly knitted together. Thoughtfully, he traced and picked out the paths along which the flames spread, looking for the pattern of where they gathered and the place they might converge next, like a hunter tracking the scent of his prey.

Chapter 194: Transmission

Vanna returned to the archives again.

She herself did not even know why she had come back. But a strange sense of wrongness and danger followed her like a shadow at her back. It made her keep going over every detail of how she had searched for information in the archives. The more she thought about it, the more she felt she had forgotten something.

Of course, another reason she came back was that she had nowhere else to go right now anyway.

Because her connection with the Vanished kept growing stronger, she was actually under constant watch. She was still the Inquisitor of the city-state of Pland, but only because no one could replace the important duty she carried right now. So, aside from necessary appearances, she had to stay inside the Cathedral at all times.

Her meeting with “Captain Duncan” in the dream made her anxious. The clues she found in that small cathedral in the Sixth District also would not leave her mind. Here in the quiet and holy archives, at least she could block out some of the stares and devices around her and let herself breathe for a moment.

Her footsteps echoed in the empty archives. Row after row of high shelves rose up to the ceiling like giants, standing silently in her view. Ancient files slept on those shelves, looking down from top to bottom at the young Inquisitor walking through the aisles.

Vanna lifted her head and looked along the shelves stretching into the distance, recalling once again how she had searched here last time. A middle-aged Father who managed the archives walked a short distance behind her, quiet and steady. The consecrated lantern in his hand gave off a warm, gentle light.

She had come into the archives, asked for the records from 1889, and found suspicious traces of a heretic sacrificial rite. Using that as a clue, she had broadened the search and found all the records of heretic sacrificial rites around 1889. In the end, she had noticed that the file for 1885 was missing, an anomaly.

These memories ran through her mind again and again. Vanna could no longer remember how many times she had replayed them. Now they appeared so clear in her head, from beginning to end, perfect, without a single sign of a missing piece or distortion.

Yet Vanna’s eyebrows slowly drew together.

The young Inquisitor suddenly stopped. The middle-aged Father walking behind her also stopped.

“Inquisitor?” the middle-aged man called from behind her.

Something was wrong. Something was very wrong. She definitely had not come alone that day to look up the files. Someone had been with her. She was sure of it. But who was it?

Vanna acted as if she had not heard the voice behind her. She only frowned and tried hard to think. She remembered that small cathedral in the Sixth District, and the nun there who had died in 1885. That cathedral had disappeared from everyone’s sight. Even Bishop Valentine had forgotten it for many years. How similar that was…

She had fallen into the same kind of “forgetting”. Every person had forgotten the same thing. That was why she could not notice the hole in her memory, and there was no one who could remind her. But what exactly had she forgotten, and when had she started to forget it?

“Inquisitor?” the Father’s voice came again from behind her.

Vanna felt the Power of the Storm begin to gather. The middle-aged Father’s hand had quietly moved toward his waist.

“How long have you been the administrator here?” Vanna suddenly asked.

The Power of the Storm scattered at once. The Father lowered his hand and bowed his head slightly. “Seven years, ever since I retired from active duty.”

“There shouldn’t be only you as administrator here, right?” Vanna asked again.

“There are two of us,” the Father replied. “The other is an older lady. She takes the night shift. She also retired from the Guardian unit.”

Vanna spoke as if making small talk. She kept walking slowly between the shelves and said casually, “Only two people… can you really handle all the work?”

“We can still manage. There actually isn’t that much work for archive administrators,” the middle-aged Father explained carefully. “There are guards on duty everywhere, in plain sight and in hidden posts. Servants and novice monks handle moving and sorting things. We only need to do the filing and retrieval ourselves. Most of the materials here never move again once they’re stored, so the workload is small.

“But because the administrator has to stay inside the archives for long periods and be surrounded by books and records, the person must be a

priest with a firm will and rich experience. Even if the workload is small, the job is still very important."

He paused for a moment, then added, "Of course, since there are only two of us, things can get troublesome when something special happens. I've always thought we should add one more person. Three people on shifts would be more reasonable."

"Three people on shifts…" Vanna whispered to herself, then asked, "You still haven't found the files for 1885?"

"No, we still haven't found them," the middle-aged Father said, shaking his head. "After you told us about the anomaly here, we organized a full inspection of the archives. We used more than a hundred servants and novice monks, but we found nothing."

Vanna gave a soft sound of acknowledgment and said nothing more. She simply stood quietly in front of one of the shelves and sank into thought. Her silence made the Father behind her even more nervous.

Vanna noticed his tension and smiled, shaking her head. "You don't need to worry so much. I only met that ghost captain once. I'm not so far gone that I've lost my mind. Besides, there are more watching eyes and detection devices on this place than I can count, inside and outside the archives. If I notice anything strange about myself, I'll sound the alarm at once. I am still professional."

"Please forgive me," the middle-aged Father sighed. "I've seen too many comrades disappear from this world forever because of one careless moment."

Vanna did not answer. Her gaze turned toward the far end of the shelves, to the place where the archive administrators usually sat. She had walked all

the way around the high shelves and come back to the area near the entrance.

In a brief daze, she seemed to see a slightly hunched figure sitting there.

The young Inquisitor’s eyes suddenly widened.

The figure vanished.

The middle-aged Father noticed the change. “Inquisitor, did you see something?”

“Maybe I saw it wrong… no. Let’s go take a look.”

Vanna threw down the words and moved forward before he could answer. Her steps grew faster and faster until she was almost running. In just a few strides she reached the large curved desk, then carefully examined the desk that hid many complicated mechanisms.

No one sat at the desk. The few items on the surface were all clearly in view.

Vanna walked behind the desk and looked it over from top to bottom.

Out of the corner of her eye, she suddenly saw something, a few scattered little parts, tossed at random behind a panel at the edge of the desk. The parts were already rusted. They looked as if they had been thrown there many years ago. From their shapes, they seemed to be pieces of a Mechanical Puzzle Cube.

For some reason, the moment she saw those parts, Vanna seemed to smell something strange. It was like incense mixed with mechanical oil, along with a sharp scent as if something had been burned.

The middle-aged Father, still holding the consecrated lantern, followed her over. He looked along Vanna’s line of sight and made a puzzled sound. “These parts… who left them here?”

“There are marks on the desk,” Vanna said. She had already noticed other clues near the parts. At first glance they looked like oil stains, but on closer look they seemed like a deliberate drawing.

Her heart pounded hard. It felt as if a harsh noise echoed again and again in her head, and even the edge of her vision began to shake. In the shifting lights and shadows, it looked as if fire was jumping and burning. These unpleasant feelings did not make her panic. Instead, they stirred a faint excitement in her chest.

Her Spiritual Insight was beating. She was observing and touching supernatural traces. The clues she was searching for really were in this archive.

Silently reciting the name of the storm Goddess Gamona in her heart, Vanna reached out her hand. “Let me use the consecrated lantern.”

The middle-aged Father at once handed her the lantern, which was covered in runes and burned Holy Oil as its fuel, the administrator’s consecrated lantern. “Here.”

Vanna took the consecrated lantern and carefully brought its light closer to the stained patch on the desk. Under the lantern light, tiny dust or mist seemed to appear out of nowhere and then quickly fade away. In the play of light and shadow from the flame, she finally saw the stain clearly.

It was dark red blood. It looked as if a dying person had dipped a trembling finger into their own blood and drawn on the desk. It looked like a campfire, and in the center of the fire stood a pillar-like object.

It was not any holy symbol used by the Deep Sea Church. It was not any divine blessing from the storm Goddess Gamona.

Yet Vanna still recognized this symbol. It was the mark of the Flamebearer.

Flamebearer? Why would the Flamebearer's mark appear inside the Cathedral of the Deep Sea Church?

Doubt rose in Vanna's heart. The four True Gods were indeed on the same side, and the churches of the Four Gods often worked together. But their beliefs were different, and their holy symbols were very strong symbols of each church. Under normal conditions, such symbols would never appear in another church's sanctuary. So why was the Flamebearer's mark here?

Flamebearer… the small cathedral in the Sixth District… the forgotten people, the forgotten events, another Pland hidden beneath the Mortal Realm…

Vanna's breathing suddenly grew faster. In that instant, she finally understood.

This symbol was a warning. It was the only message left to the Mortal Realm by a Guardian whom everyone had already forgotten, on his lonely battlefield.

"Someone has corrupted history!"

The young Inquisitor suddenly cried out and snapped her head around to look at the middle-aged Father behind her.

The archives were empty.

As if from the very beginning, she had been alone here.

—

Chapter 195: Disappearance

With a sharp clang, the silver fork in Dante Wayne's hand fell onto his plate.

In the slightly empty dining room, the sound of the fork hitting the plate felt unusually loud. The maid standing by the side was startled. She hurried forward to ask: "Mr. Dante?"

Dante did not answer the maid. The governor of the city-state still sat there in a daze, as if his soul had left his body for a moment. Only after a long while did he suddenly blink. His awareness rose back to the surface like someone breaking free from drowning. Sounds from the Mortal Realm exploded in his ears.

He took a sharp breath and heard the maid's voice again: "Mr. Dante, are you all right?"

Dante Wayne stared blankly at the fork lying in his plate. He slowly reached out and picked it up, and saw that his hand was shaking badly. Countless tangled and chaotic memories were racing through his mind and piling on top of each other. A burning pain spread around his eye socket. His Ruby Prosthetic Eye felt as if it were on fire.

He suddenly turned his head. Before the maid could speak a third time, he broke the silence in a low voice: "Has Vanna sent any message through anyone?"

The maid froze for a moment. She looked at the respected governor in confusion. "…Who is Vanna?"

In the next second, the maid shrank back in fright from the sudden iron-blue color of his face and the heavy pressure that filled the air around him.

Dante Wayne's face changed at once, and the air around him seemed to grow heavier. He kept his dark expression for a few seconds, then still forced himself to stay calm. He waved his hand at the maid and spoke as evenly as he could: "You can go for now. Don't come back in for the moment."

The maid left, confused and a little nervous. The dining room fell completely silent. Dante Wayne sat quietly at the end of the long table, the only person beside the huge table.

It was as if for the past eleven years he had always been like this, eating alone at the table, living alone in this large and empty house.

Layer upon layer of mixed and disordered memories crossed and stacked in his mind. Different Mortal Realms from different levels seemed to be trying to overwrite his memories. But Dante just sat there quietly, letting his memories be overwritten again and again. He muttered like someone talking in his sleep, over and over: "Vanna is still alive… Vanna is still alive…"

He suddenly raised his head.

At the other end of the dining table, a figure had appeared without him noticing.

It was himself, at least, it looked like another version of himself.

It was a gray-white figure, wearing the same clothes as Dante Wayne, with the same face and hair. Even the wrinkles on the backs of its hands were no different. But its features were a little blurry, and its eyes were nothing but two hollow pits filled with endless emptiness and strangeness.

Dante quietly fixed his gaze on the gray-white “himself” at the other end of the table. The other also slowly raised its head and looked at him in silence. After a long time, the gray-white figure suddenly grinned. It showed a soundless smile, and in its deep eye sockets, chaotic light and shadow swirled.

The thing spoke. The skin on its face wriggled with the movement of its lips, constantly cracking open and healing again: “Ah, your heart finally sprang a leak, ‘myself’, mister.”

Dante Wayne stopped his muttering. He stared hard at the figure sitting across from him, this reflection that belonged to him. “What did you do?”

“To be honest, I don’t know,” the thing on the far side of the table said, shaking its head. “It just happened. The surprise came too fast. A loophole chose to destroy itself.

“But don’t you want to see all this? You don’t have to carry the pressure of the truth anymore. You don’t have to worry about duty or the future. Everything is going back on track. Eternal release and peace are waiting for everyone, just like the promise you got many years ago. Everyone’s wish will be fulfilled…”

As it spoke, the gray-white thing slowly stood up from the table. A twisted, broken smile spread across its face. “I know your heart very well. I know it like I know myself…”

Dante Wayne also slowly stood up. There were no weapons in the dining room, but he always carried a short dagger with him. Now he gripped this only blade tightly and stared at the gray-white figure. “You’re nothing but a hollow thing, an empty shadow. And you think you deserve to know the human heart?”

“I am the soul you reflect in Subspace…” The gray-white figure spread its arms, as if it did not care about Dante’s hostility and challenge at all. “Subspace knows everything, including that shallow, laughable human heart… Come on, kill me, and then see me again. It feels like we haven’t played this ga—”

The gray-white shadow’s words cut off.

Dante Wayne stared in shock at the other end of the dining table. He saw an emerald flame that had somehow spread here from somewhere unknown. Like a predator that had smelled prey, it suddenly leaped at that phantom. The phantom tried to dodge, but the fire seemed to ignore the rules of space and burst into a fierce blaze on its body.

A shrill scream and a strange howling sound came at the same time. The sharp sound waves shattered all the glass in the dining room in an instant. But the sound itself was locked inside this space and could not spread outward. So the layers of echoed sound waves kept bouncing around the room, growing stranger and more chilling.

Dante Wayne watched in a daze as his Subspace projection twisted in the fire into a strange, writhing pool of grease. The grease still gave off roars and shrieks. He could only barely pick out a few words. Besides poisonous curses, there was only one word with any clear meaning: “the Vanished!”

That word was almost screamed out by that pool of grease.

Then the grease burned away as well. Only pale ash remained in the flames. Dante Wayne stared blankly at it all. In the next second, burning pain suddenly filled his whole body.

The burning of the Subspace projection was now reflecting back on his true body.

The dagger fell to the floor, and the governor’s fairly strong body dropped after it. Dante Wayne curled up in agony, feeling as if his own body were being burned by the flames. This delayed burning was tearing and destroying his soul and mind. But in the rising illusion of fire, he saw that the spreading green flames were only circling around him slowly, not really hunting him.

Those spirit form flames finally drifted in a circle and flickered twice in front of the governor, then quickly spread away toward somewhere else.

Dante even felt that the flame spat once, as if it were showing its disgust for food that did not suit its taste.

He thought the pain of burning had already driven him insane.

In the next moment, all the pain left as suddenly as it had come. Dante felt his mind jolt like a spring pulled to its limit and then suddenly released. That sudden relaxation became the last blow to his awareness. A strong wave of dizziness swept over him. His vision went black, and his sense of the world rushed away from him.

Just before he completely lost consciousness, he heard the front door open, the maid’s cry of alarm, and the messy footsteps of others rushing in.

…

Vanna calmly looked around the empty archives, trying to find any trace of the middle-aged Father.

For the first two minutes, she did not move from where she stood. She did not try to leave, and she did not touch anything in her field of vision.

This was to avoid touching the source of some corruption while trapped in an illusion, letting her mind be invaded.

Only after she confirmed that everything she could see was solid and normal, and after she placed mental protections on herself again, did she go behind the administrators' curved desk and firmly press a button under the surface.

That button rang the alarm bell.

The bell began to ring, echoing again and again in the empty archives.

Vanna looked down again at the consecrated lantern in her hand.

The middle-aged Father had vanished, but the lantern he had lent her was still in her grasp. It gave off a gentle, warm light. Though the archives were not dark, the holy fire burning the oil still seemed to drive something away. It formed a hazy circle of light several meters around her.

Vanna walked another circuit around the administrators' rest area. She still could not find any sign of the Father.

The alarm bell kept ringing, sharp and piercing, making her heart pound.

Vanna returned to the curved desk. Her eyes fell on the scattered parts and the mark written in blood.

The bell echoed hollowly. No one came in.

The young Inquisitor suddenly understood.

It was not the middle-aged Father who had disappeared.

It was her.

The moment this thought rose from her heart, Vanna felt the atmosphere around her change. It was as if a layer of the Veil had been torn away. Another dimension, laid over the Mortal Realm, revealed its true face to her. Her eyes flew wide. She saw endless flames flaring up all across the archives.

And in that sea of roaring fire, a tall, thin figure holding a Black Umbrella had appeared at some point and now stood not far in front of her.

The figure was very tall and very slim, and a strange aura rose from his whole body. Standing in the flames, he raised one arm toward Vanna. A low, hoarse voice came from deep within him: “You…”

Vanna heard only one syllable. In the next second, she had already swung the huge greatsword off her back, a weapon that ordinary people would need both hands just to lift. One hand held the consecrated lantern, the other raised the greatsword. From three meters away, she leaped into the air and brought the blade down in a heavy chop.

“Heretic!”

Chapter 196: Berserker-Style Fighter

Vanna did not actually recognize right away what the figure that suddenly appeared in front of her was. The figure's whole body was hidden under a long black coat and a big black umbrella, and her own mind had just taken a brief shock from suddenly peering beyond the Veil, so she had lost her usual sharpness for a moment.

But when the monster opened its mouth and let out a hoarse, low noise, when its foul, blasphemous breath spilled out, and when, as it raised its hand, the twisted outline shaped by corruption showed itself, she recognized it.

It was a heretic, a heretic of the Sun.

That made things simple—Vanna liked simple things.

The heavy alloy greatsword howled as it cut through the air, and the holy consecrated lantern drove away the foulness around her. Vanna leaped high, her figure like a huge wave. When she came down, that strike carried the full force of a crashing wave—tons of seawater seemed to gather into that one sword. The umbrella-holding heretic of the Sun clearly had not expected her to be so decisive and lost the chance to dodge. It could only raise the black umbrella in a hurry to block.

Then, like a small boat broken by a huge wave, both it and the umbrella were split cleanly in two.

The spawn remnant, cut in half, flew off into the distance, filthy, blasphemous flesh splashing all along the way. The large umbrella made of tough alloy was also cut into two halves and fell to the ground with a clash of metal. Tiny blue sparks kept jumping from the broken ribs and handle, and shards of crystal burst from its frame, the faint glow inside them quickly fading away.

Vanna stepped forward and crushed the scattered parts under her boot, but her eyes were already on the pieces of flesh she had cut apart not far away. They were writhing and knitting back together at a shocking speed. In no time, that tall, thin figure in the long black coat appeared again in the sea of fire. This time, without the black umbrella to cover it, the ugly true face of that blasphemous thing showed clearly in Vanna’s sight.

Its head was like a flower of flesh opening in bloom, and its body was made of countless twisted, coiled tentacles. Right now that flower of flesh was letting out an angry, shrill scream. The sound was enough to knock an ordinary person out on the spot, but it only made Vanna smile a little.

Regeneration did not mean invincibility. This thing was weakened, and after losing the protection of that strange black umbrella, it looked to be in great pain.

The young Inquisitor casually hooked the consecrated lantern back at her waist and shifted her grip on the sword. Holding it with both hands, she strode toward the monster. But then, suddenly, the corner of her eye caught a brief distortion in the flames beside a bookshelf.

Years of battle experience and sharp danger sense made her stop at once and turn around. The next second, a coiled tentacle shot out of the warped flames. A piece of steel plate, glowing red from the heat, was wrapped up by that tentacle and hurled at her like a cannon shell!

At the same time, the heretic of the Sun that had just finished regenerating suddenly turned into a black blur and rushed in from the side to ambush her. In a flash of light and shadow it crossed the distance to within a few meters of Vanna. Two long whips of flesh snapped out from its hands, lashing toward Vanna's neck and back at the same time.

Vanna clicked her tongue, twisted her body, and swung up the sword. She simply threw the greatsword like a huge spear straight at the ambushing heretic of the Sun. The greatsword was heavy and fast. With a boom it smashed the attacker away and nailed it to the wall more than ten meters away. At the same time, the red-hot steel plate flew up in front of Vanna. She raised a hand to block. The glowing steel stopped as if it had hit a mountain. Where her fingers gripped it, steam hissed up from steel and flesh, and the metal visibly warped and curled under her grip.

"So it really is you lot causing trouble." Vanna seemed not to feel any pain at all. She casually tore the steel plate in half and threw it aside. Then she beckoned behind her. The greatsword that had pinned the enemy to the wall was pulled by an invisible force and flew straight back into its master's hand, dragging along the writhing, howling remnant of the Sunspawn.

Vanna flicked her right hand and tossed the monster impaled on the sword to the ground. Without even looking back, she left the quickly regenerating monster there and walked forward, leaving only one sentence behind: "You go ahead and finish regenerating here. I'll go purify your friends."

The mass of writhing flesh that had been pierced by the greatsword and had lost the shelter of the black umbrella let out a frenzied roar, as if spewing blasphemous, furious Subspace curses. But Vanna had already done the math on this thing's regeneration speed. She knew that, after taking a heavy blow and losing the umbrella's protection, its recovery had slowed a lot. So she paid it no mind and strode toward the burning bookshelf not far away.

Another figure had stepped out of the flames there—the second heretic of the Sun.

This was the one that had thrown the steel plate just now.

Looking at the Inquisitor who was striding toward it, the tall, gaunt shadow let out a chain of low, muffled whispers and roars. As its disgusting, sticky limbs writhed, tentacles stretched out from inside its “coat.”

“Fear, anger, confusion… looks like you have emotional reactions too. You aren’t just a bunch of ‘split-off bodies’ without complete minds, like many people think.” Vanna walked forward, watching for more ambushers as she spoke in a calm voice. She was not someone who liked to talk a lot, but against the mad, blasphemous whispers of monsters like this, the rational words of a cleric were also an effective weapon. “Remnants of the Sunspawn… Since you are here, that means at least one Sunspawn body is also hiding nearby. Where is it? Deep in the sea of fire? Outside the Cathedral? Or…”

At that moment, the monster attacked. A shadowy lash sprang up beside it and whipped hard toward Vanna’s neck.

Vanna turned her body slightly and casually caught the tough, bone-spurred tentacle in one hand. Her wrist gave a sharp, sudden twist.

“…in that great fire in 1889? Or in that little Cathedral back in 1885?”

The tentacle in Vanna’s hand burst into a cloud of blood. That exploding blood mist then rushed back along the tentacle toward the monster not far away. Only when the whole tentacle and a third of the monster’s body suddenly exploded did the shock finally fade. In the next second, Vanna had already charged behind the monster. Her greatsword rose high, then swept sideways like a club and smashed into the monster’s side.

With a loud bang, the monster’s howl stopped at once. It flew off like a lump of filthy meat and landed in the distance, right next to the first Sunspawn remnant.

At that moment, the first remnant was just about done regenerating. In the writhing flesh you could already vaguely see the tall, thin shape, and the “black coat” it had mimicked into being, which was really some kind of protective shell.

Vanna walked up to the two attackers and looked down at the two monsters.

“Even though I don’t know how the Black Sun can meddle in the corruption of history, and I don’t know what surprises the ‘true body’ behind you has prepared for me, there is one thing that must be right.

“I’m going to fight you here to the very end and see if you are really endless or not. Either I kill my way out of here, or… I prove my loyalty and true faith to the Goddess.”

The greatsword rose, and then…

…came a long series of careful cuts.

Vanna’s thinking was very simple. The spawn of the Sun had powerful regeneration, but no matter how strong the healing, it was not invincibility. As long as their recovery cost them something, then dealing with them was not a problem.

Finely chopping them into mince would do. If that still did not work… then chop them twice.

…

Shirley opened her eyes and saw a ceiling she still was not very familiar with, and the sunlight pouring in through the nearby window.

The bed under her body was very soft and comfortable. The blanket over her carried a fresh, dry smell. In the shantytown, it was hard to find that kind of dryness. The oldest pipes and blocked sewers all gathered in those filthy alleys, and the air there was always damp and stinking. Even if you dried a blanket in the air for three days, all you did was let the sewer stench soak deep into the cloth and cotton.

Shirley lay there quietly. The comfort was almost too much, and she did not even want to roll over. But in the end she pushed herself up with her hands and looked around.

Nina was no longer in the room, and judging from the sunlight outside the window… it was probably already close to noon.

“Dog…” Shirley called softly. “How long did I sleep?”

Dog’s voice rang in her mind at once: “It’s at least half past ten now, maybe eleven. Yesterday you finished eating, took a bath, and then fell right onto the bed and passed out. You’ve been out for at least twelve hours… which is normal. You burned a lot of energy.”

Shirley was still a little groggy. The things that had happened yesterday drifted through her mind like a dream. It took her a long time to sort out her memories and decide which parts had really happened and which were strange scenes from her sleep.

Then she lifted her head and looked toward the corner of the room.

A simple little chest was sitting there quietly.

Ah. That was everything from the past ten-plus years… everything she and Dog owned.

“We really… moved here.” Shirley muttered to herself. “Dog, it feels like a dream.”

“Stop saying that. I’m already nervous enough as it is. Mr. Duncan is in the kitchen cooking. I really don’t even dare to imagine what we’re going to see on the table in a while…”

“Dog, why do you have such a big problem with the food here? You’ve gone on about this more than once…”

“Ugh, just don’t ask…”

Listening to Dog’s complaints, Shirley suddenly laughed.

The sunlight today was really nice.

Chapter 197: Bright Sunshine

The sunlight outside the window was bright and warm. The terrible weather from before now felt like a distant illusion. Only the water marks left on the windowsill and the wet ground on the street proved that a heavy rain had really fallen late last night. And this sunny day after the rain seemed just right for sleeping in at home.

But Shirley had already slept enough. She had never slept this long in one go before, and she was a little hungry, which pushed her to get up quickly.

Lying hungry in bed was not a pleasant memory for her. When she was younger, she had used sleep to get through the hungriest nights. If not for Dog waking her up and supporting her, she might have left this world long ago on some cold, hungry winter night.

When hunger passed a certain point, a person brushed shoulders with death in their sleep. That was one of Shirley’s hard-earned life lessons.

She left the soft, comfortable bed and got up to change clothes. At that moment, light, quick footsteps sounded right outside the door.

“Shirley! Are you awake? I heard something!”

It was Nina’s voice.

Shirley froze for a second, then quickly answered: “I’m awake.”

The door opened, and Nina appeared in the doorway in a white blouse, short jacket, and light brown plaid skirt. She saw Shirley, who had just finished changing, and smiled at once. Then she walked quickly over. “You

really slept a long time! How do you feel now? Does your back still hurt? How are your wounds… let me see, let me see…”

“I used a lot of energy, so I slept for a long time… I’m fine now, really.” Shirley dodged a little at Nina’s overenthusiastic checking. But the girl who was usually so strong and powerful seemed to have no strength at all when trying to avoid Nina. In the end, she obediently turned around and let Nina check the wounds on her back and arms. “They’re just small injuries. I… heal very fast. And… hey, that tickles, don’t… it tickles, haha…”

“They really all healed!” Nina finally let go of Shirley, who had started hopping and squirming away from her fingers. Nina stared at her friend in surprise, as if she were studying some rare creature. “Last night it was still such a big wound. Now it’s not only gone, it didn’t even leave a scar… How did you do that?”

“I already told you, I have a symbiotic pact with a Abyssal demon. Dog’s traits are a tough body and regeneration,” Shirley said, straightening her clothes. The outfit she had worn yesterday had been ruined in the fight. The one she was wearing now was another old set she had brought from home, one of the few things she had managed to salvage after the attack. “My regeneration could actually be even better, but Dog says I’m malnourished, so my regeneration is kind of weakened…”

“Then you need to eat well here. Uncle’s cooking is really good now,” Nina said at once, then grew curious. “So… are all people like you… I mean, people who have symbiotic pacts with Abyssal demons, are they all this strong?”

“It depends on what kind of demon they have a symbiotic pact with. If it’s a Abyssal Hound, what you get is toughness and regeneration, plus a boost to your senses. With dreadfiends, what you get is willpower and resistance to mental corruption. Besides those, there are all kinds of demons, and I can’t

name them all… Anyway, people with symbiotic pacts with Abyssal demons are the messiest kind of supernatural. Those demons are always very generous to their pact partners, just so they can act in the Mortal Realm."

Shirley suddenly paused there, and her expression turned serious. She looked into Nina's eyes. "That's just talk, though. I still think you shouldn't get too close to this side of things. By now you should know that, under normal circumstances, the ones who make symbiotic pacts with Abyssal demons are all madmen from the Cult of Annihilation. They're not like me. Their demons aren't like Dog."

"I know, I know, I'm not a little child," Nina said quickly, waving her hands, but she still could not hide the curiosity on her face. "But have you ever seen other people with symbiotic pacts? I mean those annihilation believers…"

"I haven't, and I don't want to. Just hearing Dog describe them is disgusting enough. If I ever do see them, I'll be sure to beat them up… and then report them to the constables," Shirley said, frowning. "Nina, you're asking a lot of questions today… You didn't ask this much even when you first met Dog. And don't you have school today?"

"I have to learn more about you if you're going to be living in my home from now on. I heard from Uncle that your house was destroyed in a gas explosion and you don't have anywhere else to go…" Nina said seriously as she grabbed Shirley's hand and pulled her toward the door. "And school is on break! We have almost two months of vacation. You didn't know?"

"How would I know? I've never gone to school…" Shirley muttered under her breath as Nina dragged her out of the room toward the kitchen, where the smell of food was already drifting out. She noticed that the whole

second floor was very quiet and could not help asking, “Is Mr. Duncan not here?”

“Uncle went down to the first floor. He said he needs to receive someone and told us to eat upstairs first,” Nina explained. She pulled Shirley to the kitchen door, then suddenly seemed to remember something and quickly turned to drag her toward the washroom. “Oh, right, wash your hands. You have to wash your hands before eating, or Uncle will start lecturing again.”

“Oh… okay.” Shirley let Nina pull her back and forth in a daze. She did not know if it was because she was hungry or because she had slept too long, but her head felt a little foggy. Still… it was not a bad feeling.

At the same time, beside the counter on the first floor of the antique shop, Duncan was carefully explaining something to the person sitting across from him. The person across from him was a young lady in an elegant dress and a fine checked veil, with long golden hair and a dignified, beautiful face.

“…That’s pretty much it. There’s an awful lot of common sense you need to know if you want to live in human society, but for now it’s enough if you understand the most basic parts. That’s enough for your current range of activity. You won’t be doing much here in the shop either. Just get used to the simplest things at first, like sweeping the floor and putting things back on the shelves,” Duncan finally finished explaining the things she needed to watch out for here. But he still looked uneasily at the golden-haired maiden sitting up straight in front of him. “And the things I taught you on the ship before… you still remember them?”

“I remember, I remember!” Alice nodded hard at once. After two big nods, though, she suddenly seemed to remember something and quickly made her nods smaller, lowering her head in a very proper, elegant way. “Don’t worry, I remember it all very clearly!”

“Right, small nods. At least you remembered that.” Duncan let out a breath and let his gaze slide over Alice again, checking each detail.

A golden wig covered her original long silver hair. A bit of makeup had softened some details of her face. A veil hid the lower half of her face. She wore long white silk gloves on her hands, and a frilled choker around her neck to hide the special joints there.

Basically, every part that could be disguised had been disguised.

Of course, if someone who knew Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm extremely well stood here, or someone who had once seen Anomaly 099 up close with their own eyes, they would probably still notice something suspicious in the brows and eyes of this “golden-haired maiden.” But the chance of that was almost zero.

Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm had lived half a century ago. And anyone who had ever been close to Anomaly 099 was almost certainly no longer alive.

Ordinary people, even the Guardians of the Church, definitely would not recognize that this Alice was the cursed Doll in a runaway state.

Duncan could not help sighing again in his heart.

At first, he had planned to wait a while longer before letting Alice come to a human city to “see the world,” to give her a few more days of lessons on the ship. But he could not stand the way she leaned on the railings, staring longingly into the distance and muttering to herself when she had nothing to do, so he moved the schedule up a bit.

Still, within what he could manage, he had crammed as much basic knowledge into her as possible, and poured the most basic “normal worldview” into her. He figured… it should be enough.

Probably.

Right now, Nina and Shirley were eating upstairs. Duncan had picked a time and asked AI to bring the doll from the ship to the shop so she could get used to the place. The first thing Alice did when she arrived was poke and prod everything in sight. It had taken him a lot of effort to “pin” her to the chair by the counter. Even so, he could tell that the doll’s attention was almost never actually on what he was saying.

She had started looking all around again. Even though she tried her best to sit up properly, her darting eyes and the neck that kept wanting to turn this way and that were impossible to hide.

Elegant, ladylike posture matched with eyes that just could not sit still—Duncan could only think: this really was Alice. Somehow, elegance and total airheadedness could appear on the same person at the same time.

After a round of looking everywhere, her attention finally returned to Duncan. Her eyes were full of barely hidden focus and… curiosity.

Chapter 198: Alice’s First Day Out in the World

Duncan felt a little creeped out by the doll’s unblinking stare. After forcing himself to stay calm for a few seconds, he finally couldn’t help frowning and asked: “What are you looking at?”

Alice answered honestly: “Looking at you.”

Duncan stared blankly at her and said: “What’s there to look at about me?”

“It’s the first time I’ve seen you talking in… this look,” Alice said, her face full of disbelief. “Even though you said before that you have another body and identity here, actually seeing it still feels so unbelievable! Captain, you look completely different from how you look on the ship. You’re not as tall, you’re not as gloomy, and… you kind of look like a good person now…”

Duncan’s eyes widened at once, but before he could speak, Alice hurried to add: “Ah, I shouldn’t slander you, Captain…”

“I’ve told you so many times, stop learning nonsense from that Goathead!” Duncan glared at the blockhead in front of him, feeling like his brain was trembling. “Calling someone a good person isn’t slander—that’s called a compliment. Even if you’re saying it about me!

“And did you forget what I told you? In the city-state you can’t call me ‘Captain’. You have to call me Mr. Duncan or Shopkeeper. Remember?”

Alice jerked and shrank her neck. “Ah… ah! Got it, Cap… Shopkeeper!”

“…How about you just call me Mr. Duncan,” Duncan sighed, looking tired. “At least you’re a bit more used to that name, so you’re less likely to get it wrong.”

“Oh, oh, okay, Mr. Duncan.” Alice lowered her head in a hurry as she agreed. She had just bent halfway when Duncan reminded her helplessly: “Don’t lower your head, or it will fall off—if you let your head drop off in front of everyone, your trip to the city-state will be over.”

Alice made a little sound of understanding, then frowned as if thinking of something. “I think I heard AI muttering something like what you just said, but it wasn’t like this… She said, ‘Don’t lower your head, your crown will…’”

“Do you have a crown on your head?!” Duncan glared. “All you’ve got on your head is a wig—and it’s fixed on more firmly than your actual head!”

Alice thought for a moment. “Hehe…”

She was quiet for less than two seconds, then suddenly started staring at Duncan again. This time, before he could speak, she blurted out: “Captain… can I touch your face?”

Duncan looked baffled. “I don’t really mind, but why?”

As soon as she heard “I don’t mind”, Alice’s hands were already on him. It seemed that after leaving Captain Duncan’s imposing “real body”, this doll’s courage had swelled to an unprecedented degree. She stepped forward and pinched the cheeks of Duncan’s current body, her eyes full of wonder. “Amazing! It’s real! On the ship, when I looked at your face, it felt like it was carved from stone!”

Duncan felt extremely awkward. He dodged backward while saying helplessly: “Are you done? That’s enough…”

Before he finished, he heard two light footsteps from the stairwell, followed by Nina's crisp, cheerful voice: "Uncle, Shirley and I have finished eating! What are you doing down here…"

Duncan turned his head with a blank face. Alice's hand was still stretched out in midair. Nina stood at the second-floor stairway, staring wide-eyed at the scene by the counter. She stared at the young lady who had somehow appeared in the shop, elegant and beautiful like a noble Miss from the Upper City. Shirley almost ran straight into Nina. "Hey, why did you suddenly stop?"

Alice snapped her hand back at once. She folded both hands on her knees and sat straight and proper in front of the counter.

She was as stiff and upright as a gorgeous doll displayed in the window of the Rose Doll House.

Nina stared for quite a while before she finally reacted. She walked down the stairs, hesitating, and carefully looked at the beautiful lady sitting opposite Duncan. Shirley, following behind her, also saw the situation on the first floor, but what was going on in Shirley's head was something else entirely—

"Dog, Dog, hurry up and look. What's that sitting across from Mr. Duncan… is that a person? Can you beat her?"

Dog's voice came after a long pause, sounding extra cautious: "It's hard to see clearly through your eyes, but the more I look, the less she looks like a person… I don't know if I could beat her, but I'm definitely not going to fight her."

Shirley was stunned. "Why? You can't even tell what she is, so why are you so scared?"

“Nonsense! She dares to pinch Mr. Duncan’s face!” Dog’s voice sounded weak to death. “Just for that alone, if she wanted to stew me, I’d have to go chop the firewood myself…”

“…Dog, you’re getting more and more pathetic.”

“This is called reading the situation—do you know how many humans spent their whole lives of wisdom just to master this essence of survival?”

Shirley ignored Dog.

While they were talking, she and Nina had already reached the first floor. She saw Nina walk over to Duncan and that beautiful young lady, and she heard their voices as they started talking.

“Uncle, who is this lady?”

Nina asked curiously, while unconsciously sneaking glances at Alice, full of surprise and guesses. She had never seen such a beautiful lady, and she had never seen any young lady have such a close gesture with her uncle as just now. Her strong curiosity made her eyes shine.

“Ah, let me introduce you,” Duncan said, clearing his throat twice to ease the awkwardness. He calmly pointed at Alice. “Her name is Alice. Remember I said before I was going to hire another pair of hands for the shop? That’s her.”

Then he pointed at Nina and Shirley. “This is my niece, Nina. And this is Shirley, who is staying here for now.”

“Hello.” Alice greeted them at once. This time she kept Duncan’s instructions firmly in mind. She sat perfectly straight, nodded just the right amount, and held back her usual bounce, greeting them in the most polite way.

But maybe some unique “texture” of a doll could not be erased. In Nina and Shirley’s eyes, Alice’s restrained posture turned into an indescribable elegance and manners, along with a certain mysterious, reserved air.

At their first meeting, two girls and one silly doll reached an epic-level misunderstanding.

“H-hello,” Nina said, swallowing nervously. Afraid of leaving a bad impression, she nodded to Alice. “It’s very nice to meet you.”

Shirley also hurried to greet her. She was nervous too, but her nerves came more from what Dog had just said. “Hello, I’m also… very glad.”

Then the whole scene froze. Both sides kept their faces tense, and no one spoke.

Shirley and Nina simply did not know how to continue. The beautiful, elegant lady in front of them looked like someone who would almost never appear in the Lower City. The two girls felt that no matter what they said, this Miss Alice would probably find it displeasing.

Alice was even simpler—her head was empty most of the time.

And the rest of the time it was stuffed full of mush.

Luckily Duncan had already expected this. When he saw both sides fall silent at the same time, he knew what was going on and quickly cleared his throat to break the silence: “Ahem, Shirley, how are your injuries?”

“Injuries… oh! I’m completely healed!” Shirley froze for a moment before reacting. She straightened up at once, answering his question like she was giving a report. “And I just ate a lot, so I’m not hungry at all now!”

“I didn’t ask that… but I’m glad you liked today’s food,” Duncan said with a smile, nodding. “You should take a couple of days to build yourself back

up. I'll make some nutritious things to restore your strength. Nina, what plans do you have today?"

"I was just planning to take Shirley to the shops on the next street," Nina said at once. "I'll buy her two sets of new clothes and new shoes—her clothes are all really old."

As she spoke, she turned to look at Shirley and stressed, before Shirley could speak: "This is a welcome gift for you moving here. It would be rude not to accept it."

"I…" Shirley opened her mouth but didn't know what to say. In the end she could only nod. "All right then. Thank you… and thank you, Mr. Duncan."

Duncan nodded, a slight smile on his face. "Don't go too far then. Be back before evening—and Shirley, you have to protect Nina."

Shirley straightened up at once. Her voice was so loud it startled Nina: "Yes, Mr. Duncan!"

Then the two girls said goodbye to Duncan and Alice and walked together toward the door. As they went, Nina kept muttering: "Why did you suddenly shout like that just now? You scared me… My uncle? My uncle isn't scary."

"I… I was being polite. I've been learning manners lately…"

Hearing the two girls' muttering grow more distant, Duncan couldn't help showing a slight smile. Then he turned back and saw Alice staring at him again with that fixed gaze.

"What are you staring at me for this time?"

"Mr. Duncan… you're really different here than you are on the ship," Alice said seriously, giving him another once-over. "You're a lot friendlier here than on the ship!"

“All right, enough with the meaningless sighing,” Duncan said with a helpless smile. He of course knew why Alice felt that way—even he knew he was always tense on the ship. Even though he had relaxed a little recently, it was still nothing like how at ease he felt in the city-state. But he did not waste more words on that and quickly turned the topic elsewhere. “Let’s talk about you first. You don’t have a legal identity, so you’d better not go to the Upper City and draw attention. For now, you’ll help out here in the antique shop. On one hand, you’ll get used to the environment, and on the other hand you can help me with a few things. Usually, when I go out, you’ll stay here at the counter. When a guest comes in, you just… wait, I suddenly thought of a question!”

He suddenly stopped, staring at the doll in front of him with a strange expression. After several seconds he finally asked, a bit hesitantly: “Do you… know what money is?”

Alice looked completely curious. “What is money?”

Duncan was speechless.

Chapter 199: The Historian’s Vigilance

Duncan felt that he had been careless.

He had only thought about Alice lacking common sense for living in the human world, but he had not thought about how extreme that lack could be. He had assumed that once she came over she could at least help a little in the shop, but he had not expected that she did not even recognize money.

But it was actually quite reasonable.

After all, when she was lying in a coffin, she had never needed to spend any money…

“Sigh… Since Shirley and Nina aren’t here, I’d better keep tutoring you,” Duncan said with a sigh, helplessly giving up his plan to go out for a walk in the afternoon. “First, I have to teach you a few of the most basic things in the human world, like currency…”

He paused, then sighed again. “Looks like I’ll really have to open a literacy class for you and Shirley later.”

“Oh, oh, Shirley, that’s the very short girl from just now, right?” Alice matched the name at once, her face full of joy. Being able to get to know someone new seemed like something worth getting happy about for her. “I heard you say she’s just like me, a… what was it called, an ‘illiterate’, right?”

“That’s nothing to be happy about!” Duncan knocked on the table. “And even Shirley is better than you—at least she knows how to dodge the fare when she rides the tram!”

“What’s fare dodging?” Alice asked.

Once again, Duncan had nothing to say.

…

Heidi let out a solid sneeze.

She stood up to close the window in the sitting room, rubbing her nose and grumbling about the recent swings between cold and warm weather. Then she lifted her head with some worry and looked at her father, who was sitting by the coffee table not far away.

School was already on break. The annual autumn vacation at all the public schools in Pland lasted more than two months. During this time, her father did not need to report to the school, and he normally had few social engagements, so in past years he usually spent this time soaking in the city’s major libraries, or else stayed at home like today, passing his days at leisure.

But for some reason, Morris’s condition today looked quite off.

He held a newspaper in his hands, but his gaze wasn’t focused on it at all. He sat on the sofa, keeping the same stiff posture for almost an hour. He seemed to be lost in thought about something, and he hadn’t even responded to the daytime maid’s question just now.

Heidi frowned.

It seemed that ever since coming back from Mr. Duncan’s antique shop, her father’s state had been like this—spaced out, sometimes showing strange expressions, ignoring other people and lost in his own thoughts.

He didn’t even go to his study—as if he was instinctively resisting books.

“Are you all right?” Heidi finally couldn’t hold back. She got up, walked over to Morris, and bent down beside him to ask with concern: “Are you feeling unwell?”

She asked twice in a row before Morris finally heard his daughter’s voice. He quickly lifted his head, and only when the buzzing in his mind eased a little did he wave his hand. “I’m fine… Oh, you didn’t go to the Cathedral or City Hall today? And you didn’t go to the clinic either?”

“The work at the Cathedral and City Hall was finished long ago. The clinic is closed today too,” Heidi said, her brow not relaxing. “I remember you already asked me that once this morning.”

“Oh, did I? I forgot.”

Morris tapped lightly at his temple, speaking a little hesitantly.

He knew his condition wasn’t very good, but he had no way to explain the problem to his daughter.

He could not casually reveal information about a being from Subspace—not only because it might anger that “Mr. Duncan”, but also because mishandling that information could produce corruption and affect Heidi.

A low buzzing sounded in his mind, interrupting his thoughts, but soon the noise died down again, letting his thinking steady.

Mental noise. That was a side effect left over from returning from the antique shop.

But in fact, compared with yesterday, these aftereffects had already weakened many times over.

Morris knew he should be thankful—after facing the Shadows of Subspace head-on, he had not only kept his life, he had even kept his sanity. It was the

combined effect of the protection of the God of Wisdom and “Mr. Duncan’s” goodwill. He had some lingering symptoms caused by his madness threshold, but after a simple self-check he was sure those symptoms would quickly lessen over time and there was nothing to be too worried about.

But before the symptoms completely disappeared, his poor condition would probably keep worrying Heidi for a while.

Morris suddenly frowned. He remembered that his daughter was an outstanding psychiatrist—he could not let her keep noticing that his mental state was abnormal.

Just then Heidi’s voice came again: “Did you talk about something with Mr. Duncan yesterday? I feel like you’ve been absent-minded ever since you came back…”

“Some… topics in the field of knowledge, very profound knowledge,” Morris said. In his mind he couldn’t stop the related information about the “Creeping Sun Wheel” from rising, and he recalled the intelligence about the current state of the Black Sun that Mr. Duncan had revealed to him. With great effort, he held down those pieces of “knowledge” that seemed to have lives of their own, drilling all through the sea of his consciousness, and he smiled at Heidi. “It was pretty hard on the brain. I still haven’t figured it out, so I’m a bit distracted today… Anyway, forget about that. I suddenly remembered, didn’t you make plans with a friend to go to the cinema on your day off?”

Heidi froze. “…A friend? I don’t remember… making plans to go to the cinema with any friend… Did you remember wrong?”

“Did I remember wrong?” Morris rubbed his temple. For some reason, he suddenly felt a throbbing heat there. His memory grew hazy in waves, as if something forgotten was waking up inside his mind. “But I clearly

remember that the day before yesterday you said you had a friend… what was the name… someone very tall, and also very familiar to me…”

Morris’s motion of rubbing his temple grew more and more impatient. He started lightly knocking his forehead with his fist, muttering under his breath. This turned Heidi’s slight confusion into sudden nervousness. She hurriedly crouched down to hold the old man’s hand. “Are you okay? Is your head hurting? Do you want me to do some hypnosis for relaxation or some calming mental guidance for you? Or find another doctor…”

“I don’t need a doctor, I don’t,” Morris said, waving his hand hard. The noise rose again in his head, but this time it was different from the earlier “mental noise”. This time, the sound seemed to be desperately trying to convey some message, desperately trying to wake something up. He felt as if another consciousness was waking inside his mind—that consciousness was still him, but had a subtle difference from his current thoughts. “I just need to remember, to remember something very important… Heidi, you have a friend, listen, you have a friend, and it’s very important…”

The worry and tension on Heidi’s face grew worse. She gripped Morris’s other hand tightly, and her words unconsciously carried the calming power of mental guidance. “Of course I have friends, but which one are you talking about…”

But Morris could no longer hear the rest of her words.

He felt a sudden roar inside his head, as if all the noise had been compressed into a single instant and then released at once. Right after that, the mental noise that had troubled him for so long vanished completely, and a flood of strange memories surged up from the depths of his consciousness. In a daze, he seemed to see that scene again—a giant, its whole body filled with starlight, formed from twisted, fused shards of

broken mirrors. Then he saw an emerald flame, burning away, and as the fire burned, the mist cleared.

This time, however, he did not lose his sanity from seeing the giant. On the contrary, the images rising in his mind seemed to carry a strange great power, breaking through an invisible Veil.

The old man suddenly lifted his head and stared straight into Heidi's eyes. "Where is Vanna?"

Heidi froze. "…Who is Vanna?"

"The city's Inquisitor, one of your best friends, Governor Dante's niece…" Morris said slowly. His breathing had already calmed, and his gaze had returned to its usual depth and sharpness. The noise disappeared, and the giant's figure faded, leaving only two sets of memories in his mind that existed at the same time yet were completely different. He could clearly tell all the differences between those memories, as if he were reading two ancient scrolls of history unrolled before him—telling histories apart and searching for the truth was one of the things he was best at. "You don't remember, do you?"

Heidi hesitated. "I… don't know who you're talking about, but your condition really worries me…"

"Don't worry about me, I'm in excellent condition right now. We should be worrying about Vanna." Morris suddenly stood up, his expression more serious than ever. "Heidi, there may be a big problem in our city-state. We have to act."

Heidi stood up with him without thinking. She could tell that her father's spirit had somehow become strangely energized, but she had no idea what had happened. "Act? Do what?"

“You go to the Great Cathedral and find Bishop Valentine, and tell him…” Morris spoke quickly, but he stopped halfway and shook his head after a tense, careful moment of weighing it. “No, Vanna may have gotten into trouble because she sensed the truth… When you find Bishop Valentine, just say that you want to seek shelter, a Highest-Grade Sanctuary. Tell him I told you to do this—that the most distinguished history scholar in the city-state of Pland told you to do this. Don’t say anything else…”

Heidi listened in a daze. She had already sensed that something dangerous and urgent might be happening and that those things could not be spoken of directly, so she held back the urge to ask more questions and got ready to follow her father’s instructions first. But then she noticed Morris picking up the coat beside him, and her eyes widened slightly. “What about you? What are you going to do?”

“…Go to the antique shop,” Morris said in a low voice.

Chapter 200: Interception

The sunlight had still been bright in the morning, but now the sky had somehow turned gloomy. Gray clouds and mist sank down over the city-state of Pland from top to bottom. Distant clock towers and chimneys became hazy ink-wash shapes in the blurred backdrop, while cold wind gusted in fits and starts, its direction restless and unsure.

Two cars drove out from the Underwood family mansion. One went straight onto the main avenue and sped toward the city center, while the other turned onto a shortcut leading to the Lower City, heading into the distance under the darkening sky.

Morris sat in the driver’s seat. He handled the car carefully as it moved along the narrow road and craned his neck to glance at the weather outside.

The sky looked even gloomier than before. The chaotic wind almost began to howl, whipping the colorful flags on nearby towers so they slapped about wildly.

The sudden turn for the worse in the weather gave him a faint sense of unease. It also made him recall what it had been like the last time he went to that antique shop.

Back then the weather had been just as bad.

The elderly man lifted his right hand and patted his forehead to wake himself up a bit. At the same time, he glanced from the corner of his eye at the rune bead bracelet on his wrist.

Only four colored stones still hung between the bracelet's finely tied knots. These stones, blessed by divine grace, gave off a faint glow in the dim daylight, bringing a sense of calm to the heart.

Rahm's blessing could keep Scholars alive for a while when they faced knowledge beyond their understanding, but that blessing had only limited effect against truly dangerous Subspace Shadows. Morris did not know what would be waiting for him at the antique shop this time, nor whether these stones could protect him as they had before.

But he still drove on toward the antique shop.

As long as he kept his curiosity in check, as long as he did not open his Eye of Truth again, as long as he did not court death by observing Mr. Duncan and everything around him, he would be safe. That Subspace Shadow had been friendly in attitude, unbelievable as that was. As long as he did not engage in any Boundary Crossing on his side, that being would not harm him.

It might even be able to help.

Morris drew in a slow breath, letting his pounding heart calm down bit by bit.

He knew he had brushed against terrible truths hidden beneath the city's peaceful surface. As a history Scholar, he had already guessed roughly what those truths were. Yet he had not chosen to report them directly to the Church. Instead, he was hurrying toward an indescribable being from Subspace.

This was undoubtedly an act of defiance, even of Heresy.

But he still made this bold decision.

Heidi had already gone to the Cathedral. Her act of seeking shelter there, together with the subtle message she carried, should be enough to alert

Bishop Valentine. Before he set out, he had also offered a brief Prayer. If Rahm still watched over him, then he had at least fulfilled his duty to warn the Church. Now he was heading for the antique shop—walking three paths at once, which would at least raise the chances of success.

Something might have happened to Vanna, and she was an Inquisitor of the Deep Sea Church. If even she could run into trouble, Morris did not dare place all his hopes on the Church.

He could only hope that at the very least the Cathedral itself had not fallen, and hope that sending Heidi to seek refuge there and give the warning had been the right choice.

A sudden peal of thunder crashed. After the booming echo, a clamor rose in the distance.

Morris, who had been driving while lost in thought, jumped at the sudden noise. He instinctively looked toward the source of the commotion and vaguely saw thick smoke rising over a distant building.

It seemed a lightning strike had set the roof on fire—bad weather and bad luck.

That building lay directly in his path. Morris muttered a curse under his breath, then turned onto another narrow road at the side and drove in.

However, he had not gone far before several crazed wolfhounds suddenly burst out of a side alley ahead. A drunk staggered after them, waving a stick. When the drunk saw the car entering the lane, he rushed over, swearing loudly and swinging the stick as if he meant to block the way.

Morris frowned and muttered: “Where did this madman crawl out from…” He pressed the horn hard, hoping to snap the drunk awake and make him move. But when the man heard the horn, he only grew wilder. Still cursing, he rushed right in front of the car and swung his stick down onto the hood.

Morris flinched at the bang. Something seemed to click in his mind. He stared into the drunk's eyes and shouted in a low voice: "Modazoro Geometric Law!"

A mass of tangled, chaotic knowledge and memories suddenly flooded into the drunk's mind, stirring up a brief storm on the surface of his thoughts. The brute probably had trouble even doing addition and subtraction beyond two digits on normal days. He let out a cry of pain and terror and bolted away in panic.

Morris started the car again at once, drove straight past the mad dogs still barking wildly at the roadside, and headed toward the street ahead, which grew darker and darker.

He had shaken off the trouble for now, but Morris's face did not relax at all. A sudden deep ditch appeared in his field of view, and a steam pipe beside the road burst without warning. Hot vapor roared out and blocked the way. His bad feeling was finally confirmed.

It was not that the weather had suddenly turned bad. It was not that trouble had simply popped up. It was not that he was just unlucky today.

Something was stopping him—stopping him, the one who had noticed the truth, from going any farther.

This was not a forceful blockade, nor a direct lethal threat. The string of accidents felt more like some kind of "stress response", like an automatic warning rule at work.

How did this warning rule take effect? How had "they" found him? Was it because of his "awakening", or some specific action he had taken?

He had only vaguely sensed the truth and had never directly confronted the hidden hand behind it, yet he already ran into this string of "obstructions".

Then what about Vanna? What exactly had she discovered, and what had she gone through, that made her vanish from the Mortal Realm entirely?

Morris silently recited Rahm's holy name and checked the colored stones on his wrist from the corner of his eye. He steered around the obstacles ahead and turned onto a main road leading straight to the Fourth District.

On a broad, straight avenue, how were "they" planning to hinder him now?

Morris blinked. Suddenly, he saw another figure in the rearview mirror besides himself.

A "person" in tattered Monk's robes, a body thin and shriveled like a skeleton, face twisted into a grotesque smile, sat in the back seat. In the rearview mirror, that withered, eerie figure fixed a gaze on Morris's eyes.

The withered, eerie figure spoke suddenly, even quite politely: "Good afternoon, Mr. Morris. Where are you headed?"

Morris slammed on the brakes and turned slightly to look at the figure sitting behind him to the side. He said: "I should have realized… When I discussed the 'Will Heim transmission incident' with Mr. Duncan, I should have realized it was you so-called 'Preachers'…" He paused, then asked in a low voice: "When did you slip into this car?"

The gaunt man seemed to smile, making the shriveled flesh on his face bunch up, and said: "Hard to say. Maybe it was yesterday, maybe it was in 1889—when you and your lady first bought this car. You are in such a hurry. Do you have urgent business?"

Morris answered only with silence. The gaunt Ender did not mind. He went on politely: "No matter where you are going, I must ask you not to pass—but I will not take your life. After all, you once offered a Prayer to Subspace in that great fire, so you can be counted as half a compatriot of ours… Ah, don't tell me you still don't know who you were praying to back then?"

Morris’s expression shifted twice, then finally turned into a bitter smile as he said: “So that’s how it is…”

The Ender raised one hand, speaking with devout calm: “As we often say, Subspace is the Promised Land. It answers all wishes of all beings and grants fulfillment in a fair way…” Then his gaze fell on Morris. “What do you plan to do next? Try to drive me out? I have learned about the power the God of Wisdom grants His Believers. They say your words can turn knowledge and memory into strength, and that the words you speak can hit as hard as bullets. I would very much like to see it…”

Before the Ender could finish his words, six deafening shots from a large-caliber revolver tore through him and turned him into a corpse. Two bullets hit his heart, one his forehead.

The shriveled body quickly broke apart into pale fragments, then scattered like dust on the wind.

Morris drew his right hand out from where the side seat had hidden it, a revolver still smoking in his grip.

He muttered: “When I’ve already got bullets, why would I waste my breath on you…”

The old Scholar grumbled a few more words, casually reloaded the revolver, and started the car again.

He knew the road ahead would still not be easy. There was no telling what else might block his way. Killing one dim-witted Ender would not end any of this.

That Ender might even come back to pester him again tomorrow. Since the man had dared to get into this car, it meant he did not care at all about dying at this moment.

Chapter 201: Piercing Through

Fire—fire burning everywhere, or fields of ash left behind after it burned out. The Cathedral was destroyed by fire, the bell tower was destroyed by fire, and the city-state itself seemed to have been destroyed by fire.

Dry, hot wind howled across the Cathedral square, now burned into ruins. Gusts whipped up drifting clouds of ash. Tiny sparks fell from the Great Bell tower above, and charred flags sagged and dropped in the wind.

A tall figure in light armor stepped onto the square. The heavy, broad greatsword in her hand scraped across the scorching ground, throwing up a trail of sparks.

The tips of Vanna's hair had already been singed by the shocking heat in the air. Her armor was damaged in many places. In some of the gaps, bleeding wounds were still visible. The flesh in those wounds writhed and was slowly healing.

She held the sword in her right hand and carried a huge rotary machine gun in her left. A heavy ammo box rested on her back. She had taken this gun not long ago while passing the armory, dismantling it from a half-ruined Steam Walker, and it handled fairly well.

Hot wind blew in, and the smell of ash drilled into her nose. Vanna narrowed her eyes slightly, looking toward the distant streets and the slow-rising smoke and red light behind them.

In this strand of "history", the whole of Pland had already been burned down.

The fire had started spreading in 1889. For eleven years no one noticed it, until it burned through the entire city, and in its slow erosion, fixed the whole city-state in a ruined state.

Even the power of the Storm Goddess had already suffered serious distortion and interference. The longer Vanna stayed here, the harder it became for her to feel the gentle touch of the sea breeze.

It was easy to burn down a city-state, but very hard to burn it down without a God noticing. Those Heretics had taken advantage of a loophole in history and had very likely used the status of the Black Sun to interfere with the God's judgment of the mortal world.

But… where exactly were those Heretics?

A low, hoarse whisper suddenly came from the Shadows between the nearby buildings. That whisper carried a profane, malicious power. In the murmurs, the Shadows gathered from nothing, turning into mind-bewitching illusions. But Vanna did not even glance toward the direction of the condensing Shadows and whispering. Instead, she casually lifted the Six-Barrel Machine Gun in her left hand and pulled the trigger toward another direction that looked empty.

Deafening thunderous roars exploded over the square. Yellow brass shells rained down. As the tongues of flame swept by, a tall, thin shadow suddenly appeared in the air. It had been hiding in the cracks between light and shadow, but was now forced to show itself and, in its haste, could only use a mass of tentacles and the Black Umbrella in its hand to block the hail of bullets rushing at it—and in that very instant of blocking, a roaring wave crashed down on it!

Vanna hurled her greatsword. The greatsword, wrapped in the Power of the Storm, slammed down with a roar, pierced straight through the Monster, and carried it ten meters away before pinning it firmly to the ground. She

paid no attention at all to the attacker that had been nailed down. Instead, she turned and sidestepped quickly, grabbed a nearby streetlamp that had already been bent out of shape, wrenched it free, and smashed the heavy steel toward her side.

The second hidden attacker was knocked to the ground by the streetlamp. Its head, ugly like a flower made of flesh and blood, burst into a mess of meat. The remains writhed and struggled violently on the ground until Vanna turned the huge rotary machine gun and swept a storm of scorching bullets across it.

Vanna muttered: “Two-man teams for hidden ambushes… It seems your tactics go no further than that.”

Vanna grumbled this, tossed aside the badly twisted streetlamp, and beckoned to call the Storm greatsword back to her hand. She set the greatsword upright at her side as a support, while still raising the machine gun in her other hand, pointing it like an executioner at the Monster’s minced remains on the ground.

After a few seconds, she frowned.

She murmured: “No regeneration?”

The young Inquisitor bent down and confirmed that the heap of scraps, which had once been part of a Sun Spawn, simply lay there limply. Not only was there no sign of Regeneration at all, it was already starting to lose moisture and vitality at great speed, turning into a pile of shriveled charcoal before her eyes.

Why? Why had these remains lost their Regeneration? Was it because their main body had suddenly grown weak? Or because these scraps had been greatly weakened for some other reason?

Vanna watched this scene with both confusion and caution. Then she suddenly raised her head, as if sensing something, and stared hard at a nearby street.

A mass of flowing green fire appeared in the darkness. It quickly gathered and spread along the edge of the square, then, as if sensing something, suddenly pounced upon the Spawn remains!

It burned, devoured, and grew stronger.

Right before Vanna's eyes, the invading green flames burned away the dead flesh, like a predator enjoying its kill.

The young Inquisitor's eyes narrowed at once. She stared tensely at the spreading green fire, utterly on guard, while all kinds of thoughts and guesses surged through her mind. Yet the flames seemed to ignore her. They flowed on their own around the area, prowling across the square, then finally streamed away into the distance.

Vanna watched the flowing, spreading fire with a thoughtful look, then set off again, walking toward the deeper parts of the city-state.

…

Torrential rain poured down. Sheets of water stretched from sky to earth. The sudden downpour from the thick clouds felt like a plot brewed for many years that had finally revealed itself, washing over everything in the city-state of Pland.

When even the force of the storm could not stop Morris's steps, destined misfortune went to work again—his car finally broke down.

The old Scholar decisively gave up on trying to start the car again. He knew this obstructing power would only grow worse, because that Ender had declared something over him at some unknown moment. That curse would not allow him to fix the car.

But the Ender's "declaration" was not an unbreakable spell. Usually, that kind of thing could only exert different degrees of mental guidance or interference over an "event". The longer it lasted and the wider its range, the more power it needed and the greater the cost it had to pay.

He could not stop in this storm.

Morris opened the car door. Bone-chilling wind and rain struck him at the same time, soaking him through in an instant and even blowing him a step off balance.

But the old man only reached up to press down his hat, gripped his cane with the other hand, and stepped into the hazy wall of rain ahead.

He did not open an umbrella. In weather like this, an umbrella meant nothing.

He was already very close to the antique shop now, only half a block away. If the weather were even a little better, he would have been able to see the shop sign.

But in these harsh conditions, all he could see was a vast curtain of rain and a few nearby shops on both sides of the street with their doors and windows tightly shut.

Morris trudged forward with difficulty in the downpour. He did not know how long he walked before the familiar shop finally appeared in his sight.

The old man subconsciously quickened his pace.

The curse the Ender had laid on him seemed to have finally reached the end of its strength. The headwind that had kept blowing against him weakened bit by bit. The chill it carried stopped being as bone-deep as before. The rain curtain was still thick, but no longer fell onto him like stones.

When there were only a few steps left to the antique shop, Morris suddenly heard a voice beside his ear—

The voice said: “Stop, you will regret this!

“Ahead there is no salvation… Pland will only be swallowed by another disaster!

“History is about to be fully replaced… What you are saving is no longer the true Mortal Realm, but an echo on a wrong path…”

Morris did not slow down at all. He rushed forward two quick steps and almost crashed through the door.

In that instant, the voice at his ear vanished abruptly, as if it had never been there.

The cold wind and sudden rain on the street were also shut out beyond the door.

Morris staggered forward a few steps. Water dripped from his clothes onto the floor. The warm, bright interior made it hard for him to adjust for a moment.

He vaguely heard talking from upstairs. It sounded like two young girls. One of the voices was Nina’s, saying: “The rain is coming down so hard!”

The other girl’s voice answered: “Yeah, it started all of a sudden… Good thing we listened to your uncle and came back early.”

Nina complained: “My hair still got wet though… Shirley, help me dry the back of my hair!”

Morris shook his head, letting the thoughts numbed by cold wind and chill rain slowly return. He lifted his head and looked toward the counter.

In the warm lamplight, a blonde lady in an elaborate dark-purple gown sat quietly behind the counter, casting a curious look in his direction.

She was very beautiful, but Morris did not pay much attention to her appearance.

What he noticed was the air of transcendent elegance around her, and the mysterious, tranquil aura that seemed to linger by her side.

It felt as if she were not sitting in an antique shop in the Lower City at all, but calmly seated in a quiet palace garden, looking at him—the clumsy outsider—with a serene, lofty gaze.

Morris felt he might have sensed some… inhuman traits on this lady, but in the next second he drew back all his perceptions.

There was a new “recruit” in Mr. Duncan’s antique shop, someone he had never seen before. No matter what this new recruit’s identity was, he absolutely must not pry into it at will.

Then he heard a greeting from across the room. The lady said: “It is raining very hard outside, old Mister. Do you need any help?”

Morris froze for a moment, then quickly said: “Mr. Duncan… I’m looking for Mr. Duncan. It is a very important matter! Is he not in the shop?”

The mysterious, elegant woman smiled and said: “He is. He said his blood pressure is a bit high, so he is resting on the second floor.”

Morris looked stunned and repeated: “His blood pressure… is a bit high?”

The blonde behind the counter shook her head and said: “I don’t know why either—after we finished talking about the matter of history and replicas, his mood has not been very good.”

History and replicas?!

Morris’s heart gave a sudden thump. He wanted to ask more, but then he heard footsteps on the stairs, followed by Mr. Duncan’s voice: “Alice, do we have a guest?”

Alice answered: “Yes, Mr. Duncan! An old man I don’t know!”

Morris raised his head and saw Duncan standing on the stairs, half his body lit by the lamp and half hidden in Shadows.

Duncan saw him and looked somewhat surprised and curious.

Chapter 202: Pulling Someone Out

Duncan looked in surprise at old Mr. Morris standing on the first floor. He was surprised by how bedraggled Morris looked and by the strange expression on his face.

He walked down slowly and greeted the old scholar: “Good day – what happened? You look like you ran all the way here straight through the wind and rain.”

“M-Mr. Duncan,” Morris finally came back to himself. He set aside the matter of the mysterious blonde lady for now, took off his already soaked hat as he walked forward, and said: “I need your help… I don’t know how to explain this to you, and I don’t know if you’re willing to act, but… I found Enders moving in the city. They’ve tampered with Pland’s history, I…”

The old man trailed off mid-sentence.

He suddenly realized how rash it was to come here asking for help. He realized how irrational it was to seek help from a Subspace being whose stance was unclear. Would Mr. Duncan even help with this? Why would he help? Did the survival of humans and the fate of the city-state mean anything to him? Did the Enders pose any threat to him at all?

Was he acting on impulse only because this Subspace being had shown a friendly attitude before, or only because the other party had happened to show interest in certain matters last time?

Morris stood there in a daze for a moment, then saw Duncan nod lightly.

“I know.”

The chaotic starlight, the broken mirror, the giant of light and shadow wearing a mortal shell stood on the stairs and spoke to him in a calm voice.

“You… know?” Morris froze, then reacted. His expression turned very strange. “Ah, right… of course you don’t need me to warn you, I…”

The old man tossed his hat aside and slapped his own forehead, as if he felt he had done something stupid. He muttered: “I’m really muddle-headed, to think you wouldn’t notice an Anomaly in the city-state. Then you must also know that Vanna…”

Duncan frowned at once: “Vanna? The city-state Inquisitor who gets along so well with Heidi? What happened to her?”

“Vanna… ‘vanished’,” Morris said blankly. He had not expected that reaction from Duncan, but still spoke on instinct. Then he hurried to add: “I don’t mean she’s missing. I mean that starting today she suddenly disappeared from the Mortal Realm. Heidi forgot Vanna existed. Everyone else forgot too. Even the city-state’s newspapers…”

Duncan came quickly down the stairs. He had realized halfway through Morris’s words that the situation was serious. His face was already grave now. “Sit down and tell me slowly. Alice, go make some hot tea – you still remember how to do that, right?”

“All right, Mr. Duncan.”

Morris saw the blonde woman with the elegant, mysterious air stand up at once when she heard Duncan’s order. He also noticed that every move this “Miss Alice” made looked slightly strange. Many of her motions were very small, full of a peculiar care and restraint. It made people think of those ancient nobles with fine upbringing and long family lines, and it made him even more curious about who she was.

But his curiosity gave way to the crisis at hand.

After he sat down by the counter, he at once told the “antique shopkeeper” in front of him about the Anomaly he had noticed, and also about the difficulties and obstacles he had met on the way here.

Duncan listened with a grave face and did not interrupt Morris once. Only when the old man finished did he murmur, almost like a sigh: “Enders… they really are a troublesome lot.”

“Those madmen who exiled themselves beyond the dimension of the Mortal Realm in ancient times always jump out from the cracks in time,” Morris said in a low voice. “They work to break the continuity of history and pose a great threat to the stability of the Mortal Realm… but they rarely get a chance to stir up something this big. Under normal conditions, the protection of the Gods blocks the Enders from seeping in, and the Flamebearer keeps reinforcing the walls of history. This time those madmen must have borrowed some other power to break the blockade…”

“Old mister, your tea.” Alice came over and set the hot tea on the counter.

“Thank you,” Morris said quickly. After coming through wind and rain all the way here, he really did need a cup of hot tea to warm himself. But after he brought the cup up and took a sip, he couldn’t help it. “Pft -”

Duncan looked calm on the other side: “Just make do. At least she really found where the tea leaves are, though the amount she used is… debatable.”

Morris turned his head in shock to glance at the mysterious lady named Alice, only to see her already leaning against the stairs, lost in a daydream.

[Just who is this mysterious person?]

Duncan calmly chewed the tea leaves and confirmed one thing in his heart.

The supernatural people of this world had indeed already discovered the Enders's "nonlinear" nature, and they had countermeasures aimed at it.

But now it seemed that those countermeasures did not always work.

He closed his eyes slightly. In the darkness of his inner vision, a distant green flame suddenly leaped up at the edge of his senses.

Morris watched in curiosity as Duncan suddenly began to "rest with his eyes closed". "Mr. Duncan, you…"

"Don't worry. Vanna is still alive," Duncan opened his eyes and said calmly. "She just… lives outside Pland's city-state at this moment."

"You can confirm her location and condition?" Morris stared, stunned. He had actually come mainly to pass on news of the historical corruption. He had only mentioned Vanna's situation in passing. In his view, there should be no special connection between Duncan and that city-state Inquisitor. He had not expected the other party to have already set his sight on Vanna.

"I'm keeping an eye on her. She's a very good Inquisitor," Duncan said. He did not explain anything more, only nodded calmly and suddenly rose from behind the counter. "Excuse me for a moment."

Morris jumped up in surprise: "Where are you going?"

Duncan was already walking toward the stairs. He stopped when he heard this and looked back slightly. "To bring Vanna back – and to see what's going on over there."

Then he paused again and glanced at Morris's bedraggled state. "Do you want to go upstairs, take a hot bath, and change your clothes? I'm taller than you, but you should still be able to wear my clothes."

[Take a bath in this Subspace lair, then put on the clothes of an Eldritch God?!]

[Even the ‘Four Great Achievements of a Mad Scholar’ wouldn’t dare list those two!]

Morris felt his scalp prickle and shook his head at once: “No, no, no, that won’t be necessary. I’ll just wait here…”

“As you wish.” Duncan nodded, then walked up the stairs.

As soon as he reached the upper floor, he saw Nina and Shirley standing at the top of the stairs.

Shirley looked uneasy. When she saw Duncan, she came over at once and asked: “Mr. Duncan, did… did something happen?”

“Why do you say that?”

“We just… heard noise from downstairs,” Shirley rubbed her hands and lowered her head like she had done something wrong. “Actually it was Ah Gou who heard it. He said the Enders showed up again, and something about historical corruption, and someone named Vanna going missing? It sounds like she’s very important…”

Nina also looked over with an uneasy face. She was clearly even more confused than Shirley. “Uncle, what’s wrong?”

“…Just some small matters,” Duncan said. He looked at the two young ladies, who had vaguely sensed unrest coming and were nervous because of it. After thinking for a moment, he comforted them: “Just stay in the rooms and rest. If you’re bored, you can go down to the first floor and chat with old Mr. Morris. It’s fine.”

Shirley gave a small “oh”. Nina looked a bit hesitant. She held back for a long time, then couldn’t help stepping forward to grab Duncan’s sleeve. “Uncle, I feel… I feel a bit scared. Is it really okay? And you… what are you going to do?”

Duncan stopped and met Nina’s eyes with a quiet gaze.

Just as he had noticed before, Nina’s senses were actually very sharp. It wasn’t that she couldn’t sense anything. She was simply too sensible.

But the situation now went a bit beyond the limits of being sensible.

“Your uncle is actually a very powerful person,” Duncan suddenly smiled and put his hand on Nina’s head. “I just can’t explain it to you yet… Stay with Shirley for now. When everything is over, I’ll tell you what happened.”

Even such a simple comfort was enough to calm Nina down. She nodded obediently, her voice very soft: “…Okay.”

Nina and Shirley went downstairs.

Duncan let his expression fade, hurried back to his own room, and summoned the pigeon AI, who had been busy eating a pile of fries on the Vanished.

“We have to go find someone,” Duncan said seriously as soon as the pigeon appeared, not giving her a chance to speak. “Official business. Important business. When it’s done, the ketchup will be doubled.”

AI jumped in place at once: “My loyalty is beyond words, beyond words!”

Duncan let out a small breath, calmed his mind again, and sensed that distant, flickering flame.

That was the mark he had left on Vanna.

What had happened to Vanna was an accident for him, but that accident had also brought an unexpected gain.

Through this window that was Vanna, he had just sensed something else – those were the flames he had released earlier in Shirley’s dream!

Those flames had once appeared briefly in the small Cathedral in the Sixth District. After the Veil closed again, they vanished without a trace. He could only confirm that the flames were still spreading, but he could never pinpoint them. Yet now… he could clearly feel those flames. He felt them all around Vanna.

He still did not know how any of this had happened, but one thing was beyond doubt –

Vanna had reached the other side of the Veil.

And now this powerful Inquisitor, bearing Duncan’s mark, had become a path for Duncan to step into that Veil.

“Spirit Realm Walk.”

Chapter 203: The Veil’s Two Sides

Rain poured down in sheets. All of Pland was wrapped in an unprecedented downpour.

It was as if the sea had turned upside down and the endless deep ocean looked down on the land from the sky. It was as if the world had fallen into an abyss. Clouds black as ink hung overhead like blocks of iron. Endless rain washed over Pland’s ancient clocktowers, tall buildings, walls, and jagged coast. At the same time, wave after wave rose from the sea, as if trying to form some kind of siege, sealing the entire city-state layer by layer from all directions.

Even the dullest person could sense something eerie from this unnatural storm. citizens ran home in a panic. Doors and windows shut tight everywhere. The vagrants on the streets rushed into the nearest Sanctuary World or relief center, or at worst squeezed into a sewer entrance or a pipe relay station. At least there were gas lamps and holy steam there, enough to give the barest sense of safety on a day like this.

Heidi forced her way through the gale and rain onto the square of the great Cathedral. Perhaps the Goddess’s protection still lingered, because the rain around the Cathedral was a little lighter than elsewhere. But that lighter rain did not make Heidi relax. It only made her more worried.

The fact that the rain here was weaker than elsewhere proved that this storm really was tied to supernatural power.

The Cathedral's guards opened the main doors. Heidi jumped out of the carriage and rushed into the holy triple-spired gate. In just those few steps, she was soaked through by the icy rain.

But she had no time to care about that. The instant she stepped into the Cathedral, she felt the air around her roiling and restless. Her Spiritual Insight was warning her, telling her that an unseen conflict was spreading out from this place as its center.

A silent Monk received her. At her urgent request, the Monk went to inform Bishop Valentine, who was praying in the main hall of the sanctuary. Heidi waited in anxiety and unease for three minutes before the revered old man finally appeared before her.

She noticed that the Bishop wore the full ceremonial robes. A heavy triple crown sat squarely on his head. He held a long holy staff, and at his waist hung the Storm Canon, bound in silver and gems.

This was not clothing for an ordinary day. These were garments worn only for the most important rituals. The heavy, splendid vestments were a burden that would make even a strong adult feel tired while walking. Yet Valentine moved with steady, solemn steps. Lightning seemed to brew in his eyes, and his presence was lofty and filled with holiness. These holy things let the old man shed his Mortal identity for a moment and become a kind of symbolic vessel. He came to stand before Heidi, looking seriously at the "psychiatrist" who had braved such weather to visit the great Cathedral, and said: "Child, what has happened?"

"I… I need sanctuary. Highest-Grade Sanctuary!" Heidi answered at once. She recalled the extra serious warning her father had given before he left and spoke with great solemnity: "I need the entire Storm Cathedral on alert to protect me – to protect the child of Pland's greatest Historian."

“Pland’s greatest Historian…” Bishop Valentine gazed quietly into Heidi’s eyes. It was as if a bolt of lightning kept jumping in the old man’s pupils. Then he slowly closed his eyes and nodded softly. “I have received your request, child. The great Cathedral will provide sanctuary. You are safe.”

“Thank you, truly,” Heidi took a deep breath. She did not take her eyes off the old man. The moment she saw Valentine’s clothing, she knew that the great Cathedral had already entered a wartime state even before she arrived. “May I ask… what exactly has happened?”

“War,” Valentine said calmly. “Someone has declared war on Pland. A storm that bears no divine blessing from the Goddess has fallen upon Pland. That is the signal of war. But not until you arrived did I finally know who our enemy is.”

“War?!” Heidi stared. “Who is the enemy? Where are they?”

Valentine gazed at Heidi in silence for a long time before he spoke softly: “Pland.

“A Pland that was already wiped out in history.”

A clap of thunder boomed. The whole Cathedral seemed to shake. Heidi jumped in fright and looked up in terror at the glass windows that still rattled in the thunder’s echo and at the heavy chandelier swaying left and right overhead. In the midst of all this shaking, she suddenly felt a faint tremor – one different from the thunder.

It was the roar of many Steam Walkers gathering in the square, and the rumble of the Church Guard’s Steam Tanks driving out of their garages.

Heidi turned her head in fear and looked at Bishop Valentine, who stood before the Goddess’s statue as steady as a reef in the sea. She spoke very fast: “Is the enemy coming?!”

“The enemy is already here,” Valentine said quietly. In the noise of constant thunder, his low voice still fell clearly in Heidi’s ears. “They arrived many years ago…”

…

The greatsword slammed down with a roar. The rubble blocking the way blew aside like dust. Vanna stepped over a collapsed, slanting section of road with her sword in hand and saw the houses ahead toppling like wax figures in a fire. Hot, heavy ash covered the street like snow. Faint embers danced and scattered among the ashes and ruins. Now and then, suspicious human shapes slowly writhed in that hot gray dust. The sight was eerie and tragic, hard to look at.

Vanna forced herself not to focus too much on those writhing Ashen Humanoids.

She knew they were all citizens of Pland. They were people she had known, protected, and loved. They had died in this fire that burned down the whole city-state. Everyone in the city-state had perished, without a single survivor.

They had died in this piece of history, yet the undying flames had molded them into these horrible and pitiful phantoms.

These scenes disturbed her feelings and her judgment.

The young Inquisitor pressed her dry, pale lips together. She felt her airways being burned bit by bit in the ash-filled air and felt her strength slipping away. Once again she reminded herself –

None of this had happened, and it would not happen.

She lifted her head and looked to the end of the street.

Amid the writhing ash and leaping embers, she could sometimes see ghostly streams of green flame flash by. That was the mark left in this false

history by a certain dreadful ghost captain. That ghost captain's position in this event was strange and impossible to read. Vanna could not see what the other party wanted at all. She only knew that his power had somehow slipped behind the Veil and spread through this ruined Pland, faintly opposing the power that twisted history.

At the far end of her sight lay the end of this trip, one of the targets she had set for herself in this destroyed Pland.

A small Cathedral whose main structure had remained intact in the great fire stood quietly at the end of the street.

She had already crossed half the city-state on foot to come to this small Cathedral in the Sixth District.

Strictly speaking, she had fought her way through half the city-state.

Vanna walked forward with her sword, passing over every obstacle. The doors of the small Cathedral had already collapsed. A long hall lit by lingering firelight appeared dimly before her.

The long hall no longer had warm, bright lamps. The neat, holy prayer altar was gone, and so was the young Nun who had once prayed there in peace.

Vanna stepped over the ruins and went to the side and rear of the main hall, where she found the slanted stairway leading down.

A dark wooden door stood quietly at the bottom of the stairs.

Vanna let out a light breath, easing the pain and fatigue in all her joints, then walked down the steps.

The rotary machine gun she had taken from the Walker earlier had long since broken down and been thrown away on the road. Now she held only the trusty greatsword that had been with her for many years.

She came to the door with her sword in hand and pushed it gently.

The door was locked, but only with a latch. No one was bracing it from the other side.

Vaguely, she could feel a breath of life on the other side of the door, and faint sounds came through.

Vanna tightened her grip. The flimsy lock did not last even half a second in her hands. With a sharp metallic crack, the door to the underground sanctum swung open.

A young, tense voice cried out from the other side of the door: “You can’t open the door!!”

As the voice rang out, there seemed to be another faint noise mixed within it.

“Your junior,” Vanna said as she pushed the door wider. The greatsword scraped small sparks from the floor as she stepped inside. The stubborn consecrated lantern at her waist still shone, lighting up the underground sanctum that had fallen into darkness. “Your battle-sister.”

The sanctuary was lit by the faint light.

A Nun holding a longsword stood carefully at the feet of the Goddess’s statue, watching Vanna, who had pushed the door open, with full alertness and gaze. She wore the old model of Nun’s dress from 1885, and her face was still very young.

In the year she died in battle, she had been about the same age as Vanna.

Vanna looked at the fully alert Nun opposite her and sighed softly.

As she had imagined, only within this corruption-twisted Veil could she step into this sealed underground sanctum before the Nun died in battle. The short moment before the Nun’s death was part of the historical corruption.

This small Cathedral in the Sixth District was the first point of distortion.

The young Inquisitor had finally uncovered the most critical piece of information. But… how was she supposed to report all this afterward?

“Sister?” The Nun with the longsword had gotten used to the sudden light. It seemed only now that she realized all the flames in the underground sanctum had gone out and that she had somehow ended up standing in total darkness. In the deep dark at her feet, something seemed ready to stir. She lifted her head and looked at the tall woman in the dim glow, and finally saw the marks of the Storm Church on the woman’s armor and greatsword. “Are you sent by the great Cathedral? Leave at once! The corruption here is already in a runaway state. While I still…”

Vanna shook her head and walked forward slowly: “I’m here to help you.”

Chapter 204: teleported Out of the Volume

“I’ll help you.”

“Help me?” The young nun frowned in confusion when she heard Vanna’s words. Only then did she suddenly notice some details on the other woman’s equipment.

That really was the Storm Church’s gear and insignia, but it wasn’t any style she knew. She had never heard of any high-ranking female priest in the Church who fought with such an outrageous greatsword. The greatsword was clearly custom-made and absolutely not something an ordinary Guardian could wield.

The “battle sister” in front of her looked as young as she was, yet was anomalously tall. She came from a time the nun did not know.

The young nun was silent for a few seconds, then suddenly spoke calmly: “…Where did you come from?”

“The year 1900.”

“I died in battle today, didn’t I?”

“Yes.” Vanna stepped forward calmly. “It seems you already know what happened.”

“The Enders. I don’t know how they did it, but they opened a Subspace rift inside the cathedral. I sent an alarm outward and received no response…”

They had opened a Subspace rift in the God’s own sanctuary?!

Vanna’s heart jolted. This unheard-of situation sent a fresh surge of confusion through her. Then she heard the young nun speak softly again: “Did I succeed today?”

“…At least this invasion, you stopped.” Vanna raised her head, her gaze meeting the nun’s eyes. “You sealed your own death and their incursion together in the year 1885.”

“Oh, that’s good.” The nun let out a breath and slowly raised the longsword in her hand. At the same time, a low, rustling sound came from the nearby darkness. It sounded as if some wet, sticky limbs were crawling across the floor, as if something were swimming up out of a pool of thick liquid. The naked eye still could not see its shape, but it had indeed begun to step into this Mortal Realm. “Then the rest is simple.”

Vanna also lifted her greatsword slightly. “This is my specialty.”

“By the way,” the nun suddenly turned her head and asked, “are you all prepared on ‘the other side’?”

“…We never received the alarm you sent, so we haven’t made any extra preparations,” Vanna said calmly, letting her breathing slowly settle into its best rhythm. “But… Guardians are always prepared.”

A roar came from the depths of the darkness. The crawling thing from Subspace finally condensed its malicious projection within this sealed-off span of time.

The consecrated lantern at Vanna’s waist reacted at once, crackling into a sudden blaze. Its bright flame almost leaped out of the glass, as if it meant to burn through all its fuel in mere minutes. The longsword and greatsword hummed and shook, and in the ringing of metal there was even the sound of wind and thunder.

Vanna finally saw the shape of that shadow. It looked like a mass of formless slime. In the middle of the slime, the young nun's figure kept writhing into view, while along its edges deformed, shifting hands and feet grew from the ends of its many tentacles. The blasphemous thing seemed to be clumsily imitating the shape of humans, but because it could not understand the rules of the Mortal Realm, it could only spawn heaps of disgusting, horrifying limbs— and it was crawling this way at great speed!

"This time I'll leave it to you, sister."

The young nun's voice sounded from beside her. The moment the crawling thing appeared, she lowered the longsword in her hand and drew a silver dagger covered in intricate patterns from her side. She glanced at the monster rushing toward them, gave Vanna one last instruction, and then calmly drove the dagger into her own chest.

The instant the nun's heart stopped, the crawling monster also reeled as if heavily wounded. Dozens of mouths of all sizes appeared suddenly across its shifting surface. A chorus of shrill, jarring screams poured out from every single mouth!

Vanna heard the sound of the nun collapsing behind her, but she did not turn her head. She strode straight toward that mass of "slime" projected from Subspace. As she raised her greatsword, she wore an unusually solemn, calm expression and whispered a benediction: "Please bear witness…"

The battle ended.

It ended even faster than wiping out the leftover of a Sunspawn.

At this node in time, what appeared in the underground sanctum was only a projection that had slipped into the Mortal Realm through the hollow in a low-level cleric's soul. Even though it came from Subspace, the "passage" limited it, so it did not have much power. The only problem was that, in this

sealed-off span of time, that projection was forever born together with the nun and never left her side.

Now, this hateful cycle seemed at last to have ended.

Vanna watched the “slime” on the floor slowly fade away and let out a soft breath. She turned and went back to the side of the young nun who had already died. She knelt on one knee and lowered her gaze. “Thank you for your noble sacrifice.”

The next second, she saw the nun’s body suddenly start to fade as well, vanishing into thin air like a phantom from yesterday.

Right after that, the door of the underground sanctum slammed shut with a bang. Sword cuts and bullet marks suddenly appeared all over the surrounding walls and floor. Hollow roars echoed out from empty air. Then she saw bloodstains appear on the floor out of nowhere and slowly creep toward the closed door…

The hateful cycle continued. Everything that had once happened in the underground sanctum began to run again as it always had. The interference of this outsider had only made a ripple in fixed history, and that ripple was smoothed out almost at once.

“How can this be…” Vanna got to her feet in shock, staring in disbelief at the marks that had appeared out of nowhere in the underground sanctum. “This is just a piece of history corrupted by—”

Before she could finish, a flicker of ghostly green light flashed in the corner of her eye. A heartbeat later, that tiny flame swelled into a huge vortex, into a standing doorway. A tall, imposing figure emerged from the fire and stepped out.

She heard that tall figure speak to her:

“Because the corruption runs deep, and the culprits have already sensed your awakening and resistance. Simply destroying one Subspace intruder is no longer enough to correct this chain of dislocated histories. Vanna, the source of corruption is no longer this little cathedral, but the entire city-state.”

“…Captain Duncan!” Vanna’s eyes widened at once. When she saw the green flames spreading, she had already known that this ghost captain’s power had pushed into “this side”, but she had not expected him to appear here in person, right inside the underground sanctum. She tightened her grip on her greatsword on instinct and almost leapt in with a jump slash purely by reflex, but at the last moment she forced down the impulse. She only stared at the figure in front of her with sharp vigilance, trying to guess whether this was his real body or just an illusion projected into her sight. “What are you trying to do?!”

“Take you back to the Mortal Realm.” Duncan looked at her calmly. “I even thought you would greet me with a jump slash like last time.”

“…I know that kind of attack is useless against you. Whatever shows up in front of me can’t be your real body.” Vanna’s muscles all settled into their best state. “You said you’ll take me back to the Mortal Realm. What do you mean?”

“Is that so hard to understand? Do you not need help right now?” Duncan raised an eyebrow. “Or do you have your own way to walk out of the Veil? Just charge straight through the whole city-state?”

The corner of Vanna’s eye twitched despite herself. She watched this ghost captain with deep suspicion.

What did this dangerous calamity of the sea really want to do?

But Duncan had no intention of explaining anything to her. He simply lifted his right hand, and a cluster of leaping green fire appeared at his fingertips.

Vanna started in alarm, raising her greatsword and stepping back half a pace. “What are you trying to do?!”

“Send you back to the Mortal Realm, what else?” Duncan said casually. “I’ve never done it this way before, though, so we’ll have to test whether it actually works. If it works, you go back. If it doesn’t… we’ll think of something else.”

“…Test it?” Vanna stared in disbelief at the infamous ghost captain in front of her. For some reason, everything he was doing felt completely unlike the records she had read. But as she watched the fire in his hand spread larger and larger, all her doubts gave way at once to pure wariness and resistance. “Stop, or I’ll—”

“The battle in the Mortal Realm has already begun, Vanna. The storm is ravaging the city-state. Your real enemies are awake.” Duncan suddenly cut off the young Inquisitor. He locked eyes with Vanna, his tone low and solemn. “The battlefield out there needs you more than you being here alone— either come touch this fire yourself, or I’ll move first.”

Vanna stared hard at the fire in Duncan’s hand and did not take a single step.

Honestly, even if she hadn’t known who Duncan was, no normal person would reach out to touch such a sinister-looking thing.

Of course Duncan knew that too. He had only been polite in giving Vanna the choice.

While the young woman was still fully focused, a strand of dimly burning fire spread out from beneath his feet. The next second, a great wall of flame

sprang up in front of Vanna and then swept down over her like a crashing wave!

Every hair on Vanna's body stood on end. Her eyes flew wide. The next instant she swung up her greatsword and leaped high with a roar. "Here—"

The wall of fire swept across, and the young Inquisitor's figure vanished into the blaze.

On the deck of the Vanished, a mass of ghostly green flame flared briefly, then vanished at once.

In the rain-lashed streets of the city-state of Pland, a tall figure suddenly appeared out of midair, roaring as she swung her sword down: "—tic!"

A trash bin was cleaved clean in two by Vanna's jump slash, and the strike left a gouged trail of compressed air more than ten meters long across the ground.

Vanna lifted her head in shock, staring blankly at this world of pouring rain and cold wind.

Chapter 205: Acceleration

Morris sat on the first floor of the antique shop, tense as he waited for time to pass.

Outside, the downpour still raged and the cold wind howled. After being blocked and muffled by doors and windows, the sound of wind and rain turned into a strange, unsettling wail, like waves crashing against a lone island in a storm, beating again and again from every direction. Beyond the shop window, he could no longer see the view on the opposite side of the street.

Nina and Shirley had also come downstairs. The two girls ran to the windows, nervously watching the wind and rain outside and whispering to each other from time to time.

The mysterious young woman called “Alice”, however, seemed to feel none of this tension. She too gazed out the window, but her eyes held only curiosity and delight— a kind of delight Morris simply could not understand.

“The scenery in the city-state is really interesting,” Alice suddenly spoke. Her abrupt voice carried a strange charm and cut right through the sounds of wind and rain. “But you all look so nervous… is this very scary?”

“Miss Alice, you’re not scared?” Nina turned her head at the sound and asked curiously.

“Not at all. It’s fun.” Alice smiled and shook her head slightly with a reserved air. “And Mr. Duncan will solve every problem.”

“Miss Alice, do you know what’s actually happening?” Nina bit her lip and asked bravely. She looked into Alice’s eyes, at this beautiful lady who had somehow met her uncle at some point, who seemed to be on very good terms with him, yet whom Nina had never seen before. “You seem… to really trust Uncle Duncan?”

“I trust him very much,” Alice answered as if it were obvious. “I don’t know what exactly is going on, but Mr. Duncan will take care of it in the end anyway.”

Her overly calm and straightforward attitude actually left Nina speechless for a moment, unsure how to keep the conversation going. Just then, an especially loud clap of thunder exploded right outside the window. The sudden boom startled everyone and cut off all talk in the shop.

Shirley and Nina instinctively covered their ears and hunched their shoulders. After a brief daze, however, Morris seemed to sense something. He suddenly lifted his head and looked toward the window.

“Vanna has returned…”

The old man murmured to himself, then repeated it again, this time in a louder voice: “Vanna has returned!”

“You mean that Inquisitor?” Shirley turned her head in surprise when she heard Morris suddenly shouting. “What about that Inquisitor? What’s this about her ‘coming back’?”

Morris didn’t answer her, because he didn’t know how to explain it either. He just let out a long breath. Even though it was only the jumbled, fractured memories in his mind suddenly pulling together on their own, it felt to him as if he had seen a ray of sunlight on this stormy day. His whole body relaxed.

The old man reached out and took the teacup beside him.

In that moment, even the hard-to-swallow tea in the cup seemed to taste… a little better.

……

The wall of ghostly green fire faded away. The dim underground sanctum returned to its earlier state, leaving only one last flicker of flame floating quietly beside Duncan so he could see this place in the dark.

Vanna had already left “this side” and now reached the other side of the Veil.

Like a bright beacon, she clearly traced out the path that pierced through the Veil for Duncan. He could feel how she had left this place— and he could confirm that his guess was correct.

He let out a soft breath and looked up at the spot where Vanna had last stood.

“…To be fair, that jump slash really is frightening.”

He muttered under his breath and then turned to walk toward the entrance of the underground sanctum, stopping near the tightly closed door.

The door had closed again. A battered body was slumped on the floor, leaning against it. She pressed her whole weight against the door, a longsword clenched in her hands, and sword marks and bloodstains covered the floor around her.

Among the crisscrossing sword marks, the numbers “1885”, carved by the nun with her last strength, could still be made out.

The cycle turned as always, over and over.

History here had already solidified. Vanna’s intervention had not stopped the closed loop of time from continuing. She was indeed powerful, but she still lacked the power to interfere with the flow of time itself.

Duncan stood quietly beside the nun for a moment, then slowly reached out his hand. Just then, the nun's body twitched. She slowly lifted her head. Her weak eyes forced themselves open as she looked with curious, confused gaze at the uninvited guest before her.

"…Oh. Just as I thought, you still weren't dead at the moment you braced the door." Duncan met the nun's gaze, his tone calm. "Is there anything you want to say?"

"…I had a brief dream. I dreamed that a battle sister appeared here. She tried to let me rest within this cycle, but she failed," the nun said softly. "… She really came, didn't she?"

"She did everything she could, but this isn't the field she's best at. Now she's gone back to her own battlefield." Duncan bent down and laid his hand gently on the blade of the nun's longsword. A tiny blossom of ghostly green flame danced at his fingertips, flowing along the edge of the sword like water. "I'll take over the rest."

"…Are you also a Guardian of the city-state?" The nun no longer seemed to have the strength to fully open her eyes. Her eyelids drooped as she mumbled softly in a half-dreaming voice. "I've never seen you before…"

"I'm not," Duncan shook his head slightly. "But I can be, for now."

But the nun seemed no longer able to hear his voice. Her eyes closed completely, as if she were slowly stepping into a dream. In the last moment before eternal sleep fell, her lips moved and she whispered: "…Please bear witness…"

"I bear witness."

The ghostly green flame rose into the air. With Duncan's words, it suddenly swept over everything in his sight. The nun, her longsword, and all the blood around them all turned to ash in the fire. Under his conscious control,

every trace of extraordinary power in this place was stripped away by this burning.

When the flames burned out, they consumed not only a single body, but the entire closed time loop. In the dim underground sanctum, only a few tiny sparks still danced on the floor, flowing along the sword marks like a trickling stream and, before they faded at last, burning away the numbers “1885”.

Duncan waited quietly for it all to end before he finally shook his head with a soft sigh. Then he stepped forward and pulled open the door that led from the underground sanctum to the small cathedral above.

For the first time since 1885, this door was opened from inside the underground sanctum.

Duncan climbed the steps, walked up the long staircase, and reached the ground-level part of the small cathedral. He passed through the collapsed, ruined main hall, past row after row of abandoned pews and the ashes covering the floor, and made his way toward the street outside.

Ghostly green flames appeared like phantoms, gathering in the air around him and spreading and burning outward with his steps. The Spirit Fire that had already been spreading within the Veil sensed its master drawing near. One by one, those flames resonated with him, converging and beginning to roar to life throughout the small cathedral.

By the time Duncan walked out through the main doors and looked back at the small cathedral, the entire building was already wrapped in a sweeping blaze of Spirit Fire.

Farther out in his sight, in every corner of the surrounding blocks, in nearby districts, and even on the far edge of the city-state, cluster after cluster of Spirit Fire also began to leap, spread, and blaze up. They turned into Sacred

beacon Torches of all sizes and slowly linked together into a continuous sea.

All of them were Spirit Fire that had suddenly shifted into “active” state after sensing that Duncan had entered the inner side of the Veil.

Without anyone noticing, they had already spread across such a vast range.

And as these flames rose, Duncan also felt something else waking within the city-state. Roars rose one after another. Ash and dust in the streets and alleys squirmed and heaved. Crimson fire leaped up in many places, looking fierce and violent.

Duncan lifted his head and looked toward somewhere deep within the city-state. “Only getting nervous now? That may be a little late.”

……

On the Vanished, Duncan pushed open the door of the captain’s cabin. He strode to the chart table, braced his hands on it, and looked down at the enchanted sea chart. His voice was low. “How far are we from the city-state?”

“Oh, great captain, less than two days’ sailing remains,” Goathead’s eager voice sounded at once. “In theory, we might now run into merchant ships or navy patrol craft running the route to and from the city-state…”

Duncan listened to Goathead’s rambling without interrupting, calculating something silently. Then he suddenly straightened, left the chart table, and pushed open the cabin door to go outside.

Goathead’s surprised voice came from behind him. “Ah, captain, what are you going to do?”

Duncan was already striding out of the cabin. He crossed the aft deck, went up the stairway, and came to the platform above the captain’s quarters. He

answered offhandedly in his mind, “From here on, I’ll take the helm myself.”

“…Yes, captain!”

Goathead’s response rang out clearly. The next second, Duncan felt the whole hull of the Vanished tremble slightly. In his senses, the ship suddenly seemed to come “alive”. Every living part of it seemed to perk up.

And when he gripped the wheel, the ship that had long been ready slipped at once into peak condition. Its translucent spirit form sails billowed even fuller. Taut lines thrummed in the air. The hull murmured in a low voice under the slap of the waves. The sea around the ship seemed to fall under an unseen pull as wave after wave rose, as if to push the ship forward.

The Vanished’s speed rose sharply.

Feeling the distance between himself and the body in the antique shop shrinking bit by bit, Duncan let out a quiet breath.

But suddenly, a strange feeling rose again from the depths of his heart.

It was a subtle sense of being noticed from afar, of being regarded as a “target”.

It felt as if, the instant he took the helm, something suddenly sensed the ship’s existence and was now sailing straight toward them.

Duncan frowned and looked in the direction that subtle feeling came from. Almost at the same moment, he heard Goathead’s voice sound in his mind:

“Captain, the Sea Mist has appeared near us.”

Chapter 206: Encounter

A towering-bowed ironclad warship sailed across the vast gray sea. A thin, drifting, icy fog rolled around her within a range of several hundred meters. The mist looked like the curse that coiled around the Sea Mist in the frozen northern waters. Even though this place lay in the relatively warm Central Seas, the chill inside the fog still did not disperse.

On the ironclad warship's deck, six triple-mounted giant main guns and dozens of secondary guns already stood ready for battle. Undying seamen wreathed in cold air hurried back and forth between the various installations, preparing for the fight that could break out at any moment.

Below the deck, the ammunition shaft lift rattled as it ran, sending propellant charges and shells up into the turrets' transfer chambers. More seamen stood at pipe junctions all over the ship, checking the flow and pressure of Divine Steam and lubricating oils being fed through every part of the hull.

At the stern, a small Cathedral had fired up its independent boiler. Steam pipes on top of the Cathedral spat out thick clouds into the sky. As the Cathedral's whistle blared, incense-laced vapor mixed with the steam and slowly spread, its scent drifting over the entire deck.

An Undying priest in a somber robe stood in the Cathedral's prayer room, solemnly lighting incense and candles before the Goddess's holy statue. His skin looked withered and pale. One side of his skull was sunken, and the corresponding half of his body remained wet and clammy, as if it had just been soaked in seawater. In his eyes, the clouded white pupils seemed to

forever brew two dark storm clouds, and within them faintly flickered the candle-flames jumping before the Goddess's effigy.

In front of the priest stood the statue of the storm Goddess Gamona. The Goddess sheltered every ship on the Boundless Sea, even if that ship was crewed by the dead. The statue's base rested atop a huge pipe. Countless thinner pipes spread out from the base like blood vessels, branching into every part of the Cathedral. The lower half of the main pipe plunged deep into the hull, piercing deck after deck all the way down to the ballast tanks —the darkest, coldest compartment, directly connected to the Boundless Sea.

A fully equipped shipboard Cathedral, its own boiler, and a network of Divine Steam pipes running through every deck had, since the naval technological revolution of 1835, become standard equipment for any warship expected to fight and cruise long-term on the Boundless Sea. These systems could effectively prevent a ship from falling into mental corruption under high pressure, harsh conditions, and constant casualties, and keep a crew from suffering collective breakdown and being seized by Subspace.

From a certain point of view, the beginning of that great revolution in 1835 could even be traced back thirty-five years, to the "Vanished Incident" of 1800. The most advanced exploration ship in human history, with the finest explorer at her helm, had sailed for a long voyage and then plunged straight into Subspace. That disaster shook everyone who cared about the art of navigation.

The priest drew back his gaze from the statue, but he could not stop his thoughts from circling around the Vanished, and around this shipborne Cathedral before him.

His cold, numbed brain and the heart that had not beaten for half a century both grew restless at the thought of what was about to happen.

“May you shelter us,” the priest lowered his head and devoutly gave benediction to the Goddess, “we are about to face the Shadows of Subspace head-on. Please bear witness…”

The electric bell beside him suddenly rang, and a small lamp on the communication console began to flash.

The priest walked to the console and opened the brass speaking tube linked to that lamp: “This is the Cathedral… yes, oil and steam are ready, and the divine blessing has arrived.”

On the bridge, Tyrian Abnomar, captain of the Sea Mist, stood quietly at the captain’s station, staring out at the seemingly calm sea.

His eye sockets ached slightly. Low, maddening whispers echoed in his mind. At his side sat a delicately built brass device. The machine was a tangle of interlocking gears, several finely crafted spirit compasses, and multiple curved tracks. At its center, three copper pillars held up a small hemispherical bowl.

The bowl was filled to about one-third with fresh blood. The blood rolled and bubbled as if it were boiling. The brass device quivered as it constantly fine-tuned the positions of its gears and spirit compasses. Several pointers all pointed toward a distant spot on the horizon.

First Mate Aiden walked over and nodded to Tyrian: “Captain, all stations are ready. The Cathedral just sent word—our Goddess has bestowed the divine blessing.”

“…the Vanished is right in front of us,” Tyrian said softly, almost to himself. He glanced at the brass device beside him. “I think ‘he’ must have sensed me too.”

Aiden’s gaze also fell on the device, especially on the boiling blood in the bowl.

The pale, bald man spoke in his deep voice: “The blood-seeking spirit compass leads blood relatives together, but it has never brought good fortune or happy reunions… it only points toward slaughter and misery.”

“Which matches our situation perfectly,” Tyrian replied lightly. At the edge of his vision, a faint black speck already seemed to appear on the horizon. “It really is here—and heading straight for Pland.”

“We can open fire,” the First Mate could not help but remind him. “We actually could have started already.”

“…No. Keep closing in. We must get into point-blank range,” Tyrian shook his head. “We already tried once, fifty years ago. Shells fired from too far away will never land on the Vanished. That ship is under some kind of spacetime distortion. There is a gap and misalignment between it and the Mortal Realm’s dimension.”

Aiden lowered his head: “…Understood. The Sea Mist will keep moving forward.”

…

Duncan lowered the monocular in his hand and hung it back at his waist. Then he tightened his grip on the wheel.

He had seen that ship.

The Sea Mist—her name fit her well. A thin layer of frozen mist coiled around the hull. At a glance, it was clearly not a normal phenomenon.

But what truly surprised him was not that extraordinary-looking mist, but the ship herself—

She was an ironclad warship that looked extremely advanced: thick armor, tall smokestacks, a well-proportioned, imposing bridge structure, and modern multi-gun turrets that reminded him of a battleship’s main guns.

No matter how he looked at it, this ship did not seem like something from a century ago. Even as a refit, he could not imagine how you would turn an old sailing warship into this.

That made him think of the rumors he had heard in various city-states about the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star.

Like how Tyrian's warship devoured metal and wreckage on the seabed, then secretly grew and refitted itself at midnight when no gaze fell upon it.

Looking at the ship now, those rumors did not seem so baseless. It was like trying to explain why a Type-59 tank suddenly made a faster-than-light jump. In the end you could only say that the Machine Spirit was in a very good mood…

Duncan shook his head, tossing those stray thoughts aside for the moment.

The Sea Mist had no intention of backing down, and clearly stood ready for battle. The Vanished also had no time to circle around. A head-on clash seemed impossible to avoid.

He did not really understand naval warfare, but in theory he did not need to worry about the fighting—the Vanished's guns could handle everything on their own.

He just felt… stunned. Stunned, and a little nervous, with a strange hint of expectation mixed in.

Tyrian Abnomar, captain of the Sea Mist, one of Captain Duncan's children.

In theory, Duncan's current identity made him that pirate lord's father.

He had never imagined he would meet the Sea Mist like this… Wasn't that ship supposed to be staying in the Frost Sea? Shouldn't it be busy raiding, pillaging, and collecting protection money in that frozen region? What was it doing here?

Tyrian coming to visit Dad? A loving father and filial son reunion?

That was impossible, just thinking about it.

Captain Duncan's story sounded more and more like the start of a family disaster.

"Captain," Goathead's voice suddenly sounded, and he actually sounded… excited. "The Sea Mist is shifting into firing posture. Should we adjust our heading?"

Adjusting heading meant trying to avoid the enemy's first direct salvo, entering battle with the smallest possible profile while swinging as many of their own guns into firing arcs as they could. Goathead had clearly prepared for a full-scale gun duel.

Duncan raised an eyebrow: "You sound almost eager."

"The Sea Mist is a fine opponent. First, it can't beat us. Second, it actually dares to fight us," Goathead said with obvious delight. "And third, it's very tough—it's packed full of living dead, and even the hull has picked up a bit of that 'deathless and unsinkable' trait. If the Vanished wants to stretch her limbs, there's no better target."

"…So in short, the child can take a beating, right?" Duncan said casually. Just then, out of the corner of his eye, he noticed several clouds forming above the distant sea and slowly spreading around the Sea Mist.

A little while later, he finally heard the sharp whistling from high in the sky, carrying a powerful force straight toward the Vanished's position.

The Sea Mist had fired first. As a technically more advanced ironclad warship, she had the advantage in range. Even delaying until they entered near range, she could still launch her attack before the Vanished.

Duncan tensed. He watched as huge water columns rose one after another around the Vanished. Each blast from those battleship-grade main guns had terrifying power. The towering plumes even made the Vanished’s massive hull shudder slightly.

But not a single shell hit the Vanished. The Sea Mist’s first salvo missed entirely.

Duncan watched the water columns fall back down one by one and thought about it. This was probably normal in naval combat. Without guided weapons and modern fire-control computers, the hit rate of naval guns would be about this level.

Chapter 207: A Loving Father and Filial Son

The encounter had begun.

The battle opened with the Sea Mist's first salvo. Thunderous booms shattered the calm over the whole sea. Shells howled through the air and plunged into the water at the ends of their arcs, throwing up towering columns and chaotic waves.

The first salvo missed completely. The second salvo missed completely. Only with the third barrage did the Sea Mist's shells finally scrape past the Vanished's side.

Spectral spirit form flames blazed between every seam and mast on the Vanished. Duncan gripped the wheel, driving the massive ghost ship forward like a moving mountain of fire. Her towering bow cleaved the waves, sending up rows of white foam and ripples along both sides. Out of the corner of his eye, he saw a black shape streak toward the aft deck.

It was a shell from the Sea Mist. After missing several times in a row, the ironclad warship finally seemed to have corrected her aim. One projectile came screaming in, heading straight for the rear half of the Vanished. This time, there was no way to dodge.

Those dramatic "twist the wheel to dodge the shell" moves did not happen in the Mortal Realm. When the Vanished sailed in the Mortal Realm, her huge hull still had to follow the basic laws of physics… probably.

The ship was about to be hit.

But in the next instant, Duncan suddenly felt his vision sharpen to a painful clarity. He could track the shell's entire path as it tilted slightly and fell toward them. He saw the distorted heat waves around it, the air driven aside by the shock, the red-hot tip of the shell, and even the faint grooves etched into its body—he cast his gaze upon that burning steel, and the steel responded to his call.

The moment before it struck the Vanished, the shell from the Sea Mist suddenly flared with a ghostly fire. It was as if the spirit form flames around the Vanished had instantly infected and assimilated it. The shell quietly turned into a streak of green light and dropped in a slow, uncanny arc into the sea of fire above the Vanished.

The shell, wrapped in eerie green flames, crashed onto the deck with a heavy thud. The whole ship shuddered—yet there was no extra damage at all.

"A beautiful catch!" Goathead's voice suddenly rang in Duncan's mind, snapping him back to himself. "Captain, how did you do that?!"

"…Reflex. I didn't really think," Duncan answered offhandedly. At the same time, more howls came screaming across the sky toward them.

He tensed again, controlling the Vanished's giant hull to make small course adjustments while his gaze tracked the dark shapes dropping from above. A second later, one green "meteor" after another suddenly appeared in the sky above the blazing hull of the Vanished.

But Duncan's ability to "catch" shells was not limitless. As the distance between the Vanished and the Sea Mist shrank, the ironclad's barrage grew more accurate and more ferocious. Her many secondary and close-in guns finally entered effective range as well. When the sky filled with falling

shells, some finally slipped past Duncan’s eyes and slammed into the Vanished’s hull.

Amid the constant thunder of explosions, Duncan saw a section of the nearby bulwark suddenly take a hit. A dark shape tore through the planks, ripping them apart before plunging into the sea. The impact blasted that part of the railing into countless fragments—

The shattered pieces flew outward and up, shooting into the air. Then they simply stopped. They hung there, frozen in place, maintaining the same motion as the Vanished herself.

It was an impossibly strange sight. It was as if the sections of hull that had been smashed apart in the Mortal Realm still formed one whole ship in some higher dimension. They only looked shattered to the eye, but the fragments were still tightly bound together.

This instantly made Duncan think of the hull below the waterline, of those broken yet fully functional bulkheads that soaked and sailed in Subspace.

The next second, he saw the fragments slowly fall and drift back. In a rush, they reassembled, the restoration looking like time itself had reversed to an earlier moment.

Duncan finally pulled his gaze away from the bulwark.

It was his first time seeing the Vanished take damage, and also the first time he had seen her repair herself. The ship could heal with incredible speed. The “healing” looked exactly like rewinding the hull to its state before the damage.

Now he understood why a seemingly far more advanced and heavily armed ironclad warship like the Sea Mist still could not win against a ghost ship from a century ago.

Subspace had completely rebuilt the Vanished, placing the whole ship inside a bizarre spacetime structure. In the Mortal Realm, it was simply impossible to destroy her with ordinary firepower.

Goathead's voice echoed in his mind, smug and pleased: "Captain, the Vanished is the best ship in the world, right?"

"…To be fair, she really is."

"So what's your plan next?"

Duncan lifted his head and cast his gaze at the rapidly approaching Sea Mist: "…We beat the child while we're on the way. We've got time to kill anyway, don't we?"

…

"Captain! That ship is charging straight at us!" First Mate Aiden's voice rang out on the bridge, with a trace of tension in it. "Something's wrong… our fire is doing even less than it did in that rushed battle fifty years ago. More than half our shells are just vanishing into the flames around the Vanished!"

"I can see it," Tyrian stood rigid on the bridge, his eyes locked on the ghost ship that was speeding toward them and already edging into a slight turn. His hands gripped the rail in front of him. His face was as dark as a coming storm. "In half a century, 'he' has grown even stronger than before…"

"Then are we still fighting?" Aiden shouted. "At this rate, I don't think we can drive that ship back into Subspace like last time! And I feel like your father must be really angry right now… the speed of that ship is damnably unnatural!"

Tyrian only stared grimly ahead. After a few seconds of silence, he finally spoke in a deep voice: "…We continue the engagement."

As he said those words, his gaze stayed fixed on the burning, gigantic sailing warship—on her stern deck in particular.

He knew that was where the Vanished's wheel stood. In his distant and yellowed memories, his Father had always stood there.

Was he standing there now? Was he casting his gaze at the Sea Mist?

Thick smoke rose from the sea's surface, and a distant rumble drifted faintly over the waves.

"The Vanished has opened fire!"

A sailor shouted in alarm.

Tyrian stood firm at the captain's station, like an iceberg rooted in the Frost Sea. But he frowned.

The Vanished had not turned fully to present the best broadside angle. Instead, she cut into the Sea Mist's path along a slightly oblique arc and opened fire while still maneuvering.

That meant only about a quarter of her broadside guns could fire effectively.

Was she just returning fire symbolically? Did she have no intention of fighting the Sea Mist to the bitter end?

That was not Father's style, and it did not match the battle from fifty years ago. In that encounter, the Vanished had fought the Sea Mist to the very last moment, and both ships had been left in ruins.

That battle ended with the Vanished's healing reaching its limit, forcing her to retreat to Subspace for a time, while the Sea Mist nearly sank and spent three full years before she appeared again on the Boundless Sea.

But Tyrian had no time to keep thinking.

The Vanished’s counterattack arrived. Unlike the Sea Mist’s first and second salvos, which had all missed, every shot from the ghost ship after entering effective range hit with chilling precision.

More than a dozen blazing green fireballs streaked through the air and slammed into the ironclad warship’s hull. In an instant, the world exploded with sound. Spirit flames boiled.

Layers of radiance floated up around the Sea Mist. The shipborne Cathedral and various sacred relics activated on their own, trying to block the spreading corruption. But even so, the ironclad’s hull was riddled with horrific cavities in a heartbeat. The burning cast-iron cannonballs were like clumps of fire landing in snow. Anything that touched those flames, whether wood or steel, melted away and vanished in an instant.

No armor mattered anymore. The Vanished’s attacks did not rely on kinetic force or explosions. They worked through higher-dimensional devouring and transfer. Under the continuing rain of shells, the Sea Mist became like a pencil drawing under an eraser. The falling projectiles “rubbed out” more and more of her. The first volley erased half her main guns. After the second, several gaping holes appeared in her sides—enough to sink any ordinary ship.

The Sea Mist’s attack faltered to a stop. Even her propulsion was more than half crippled at once.

Tyrian’s eyes widened.

Something was wrong… completely wrong. This was nothing like last time.

He did not recognize this ship. This was not the Vanished from his memories.

And in that stunned moment, he noticed that the Vanished had suddenly ceased fire.

The ghost ship swelled with wind. Every sail billowed. She dragged up a wall of waves as her speed surged to the limit, and she charged straight at the Sea Mist.

“…Hard to port! Dodge her! Dodge!”

First Mate Aiden roared. The helmsman was already straining at the wheel, trying to turn the warship aside to avoid the imminent collision—but all their efforts failed.

“The helm isn’t responding!” the helmsman cried in panic. “It’s turning on its own! We’re steering right into them!”

Just as the helmsman said, the Sea Mist was steering herself toward the ghost ship.

Tyrian had already sensed the anomaly. He heard the machinery under his feet screaming in protest. He heard every window around them click and rattle. He saw the remaining turrets on deck droop their barrels one after another. In the great hollows blasted into the hull, emerald flame surged higher and higher.

This was a nightmare that had not appeared even in that brutal battle fifty years ago—

The Sea Mist had recognized her flagship.

Chapter 208: A Single Exchange After a Century Apart

Over the vast Boundless Sea, two warships that each carried the curse sailed straight toward one another. Around the two great ships, the sea had been stirred into restless turmoil by invisible forces, and even the sky within a wide range had changed.

Around the Sea Mist, the cold fog spread outward. Floes of ice of all sizes began to appear out of thin air on the surface, even forming ice fields that covered several nautical miles. They slowly turned like a whirlpool. The sea that had been fairly calm now rose in heavy, surging waves, each one stronger than the last, with chaotic cold winds howling between them.

The Vanished, wrapped layer upon layer in ghostly green flame, cut through all these extreme weather signs like a blazing spear. It drove straight toward the Ironclad Warship at the center of the ice field.

The Sea Mist also sped up. Every engine howled like a dying beast. The rudder turned on its own with no one at the helm. The steam whistle of the Cathedral carried on the ship never stopped. That sacred sound now rang out like a Death Knell.

Undying sailors stood on the deck, at the gun positions, and behind every porthole. They watched, eyes wide open, as the warship under their feet charged straight toward the burning ghost ship.

On the bridge, Tyrian could already faintly see the figure on the high stern of the Vanished.

He saw that tall man gripping the wheel, standing on the ship like a reef in a storm. The man looked at Tyrian with a cold, gaze.

He looked so much like the figure in Tyrian’s memory.

Then, as expected, the two ships “collided”.

The imagined destructive impact and breaking apart did not come.

In the next minute, the crew members of the Sea Mist were lucky enough to witness the same kind of terrifying, strange “spectacle” that the White Oak had once encountered. The burning ghost ship rolled over them like a mountain. Ghostly flames surged higher and higher. In those flames, the boundaries of all things blurred.

The Sea Mist turned into a spirit form. The crew members also turned into spirit forms. It looked as if one phantom had crashed straight into another.

First Mate Aiden stared in horror. He saw the bow and masts of the Vanished rush straight toward him, then pass right through him without leaving a scratch. For a brief moment, he broke into one of the Vanished’s cabins. He saw ancient pillars and burning consecrated lanterns roar past, so close they almost brushed his ears.

At the very end, he saw the high deck at the stern of the Vanished, and the tall figure standing behind the wheel.

Tyrian instinctively stepped back half a pace. But in the next second, he straightened his back again, as if his father’s teachings from childhood still rang in his ears.

“Do not back down. Do not bow to the wind and waves.”

So he lifted his head and faced the storm in front of him—faced the father who had been taken away by Subspace and then returned to the Mortal Realm.

Now they stood face to face at an extremely close distance. The stern structure of the Vanished pushed right into the bridge. Duncan stood only a few steps away from the captain's chair of the Sea Mist.

For a moment, it felt as if the whole world went quiet.

A low, majestic voice reached everyone's ears: "I am very busy."

Tyrian's eyes widened in shock. He snapped his head toward the source of the voice.

But the brief meeting had already ended. The two phantoms, both sailing at full speed, overlapped for only a very short instant. The Vanished's ghostly hull swept past the Sea Mist like a gust of wind. By the time Tyrian came back to himself, he found that he and his crew had already returned to solid, physical form.

He ran to a viewing window on the other side and saw the Vanished racing full speed toward Pland, leaving the Sea Mist far behind.

The Ironclad Warship slowly came to a stop on the sea. The invisible force that had driven the ship faded. Control returned once more to the hands of the helmsman.

The badly damaged engine system was finally shut down under the sailors' efforts, but it was clear it would not be easy to start it again.

"…What just happened?" Aiden scratched his bald head. The strong First Mate looked stunned. "That ship… just left like that? Weren't we supposed to fight to the death?"

A sailor spoke, still shaken: "…It didn't seem like it wanted to fight us to the death from the start. It barely even slowed down. It just came over and rolled right over us once…"

"Too scary. I even feel like my heart started beating again just now…"

The noise of the crew reached Tyrian’s ears, but he had no mood to listen.

Right now, only one short sentence kept echoing in his mind.

“I am very busy.”

His father had said it. There had been almost no emotion in the voice. It could not be called a greeting between family at all. It was as cold as if Duncan were facing a stranger. But it was, without a doubt, a sentence that humans could understand, clear and rational.

It was not the mad roaring that belonged only to Subspace.

“Captain,” First Mate Aiden came over, looking uneasily at the silent Tyrian. “What do we… do next?”

Tyrian woke from his thoughts and lifted his head. “Can the ship still move?”

“Not really. The engines are shut down now. It will take some time to fix them. And quite a few people were hurt in the battle just now… pretty serious injuries. The kind where they broke into pieces and we have to shovel them up for a long time.” Aiden shook his head. His shiny bald forehead glinted faintly. “But the strangest thing is, the people who took a direct hit from the Vanished’s guns are all fine. Main Guns One and Three are completely gone, but the people in the turrets fell down into the holes without a scratch…”

“People shaken by the shockwave were badly hurt, but the ones hit directly did not die?” Tyrian repeated in surprise, then frowned. “How could that be…”

“Maybe… your father did not go for the kill?” Aiden glanced at his captain and spoke carefully. “Judging from the Vanished’s bombardment, it seemed like it only wanted to make the Sea Mist stop…”

“That’s not…” Tyrian started on reflex, but then shut his mouth. After a few seconds of silence, he shook his head slightly. “Get the ship back under power as soon as you can. At the same time, send a message to Pland. Tell them we did our best to intercept, but the Vanished still headed toward the city-state… The rest, let the much larger City Navy handle. We have already done what we could.”

Aiden accepted the order at once and left. But not long after, he rushed back in a hurry.

“Captain! We can’t reach Pland!”

“Can’t reach them?” Tyrian’s brow tightened. “Is the signal environment still disturbed by the battle just now?”

“No. We can still receive signals from the offshore patrol points, but we cannot receive anything from Pland. Nothing at all.” Aiden spoke fast, his face full of confusion. “It’s like the whole of Pland has vanished from the radio. At this distance, that is impossible.

“And it’s not just the telegraph. The Psychic Call from the Cathedral has no response either!”

“The Psychic Call has no response?!” This time, Tyrian’s expression changed clearly. At the same time, he thought of the Vanished’s mad dash toward Pland at any cost. A strong unease finally rose in his heart. “When did communications cut off? Is anyone watching the telegraph station?”

“The last call was yesterday. We made the routine report to the harbor office in Pland. Everything was normal then.” Aiden thought back and spoke quickly. “Captain, what do we do? Do we still return?”

He paused here, looking a bit hesitant. “This… this is already beyond the original plan.”

Tyrian’s face stayed tense. He did not speak for several seconds. At last he let out a long breath.

“We go to Pland—once the Sea Mist is repaired enough to move, we set out.”

Aiden looked surprised, but after a brief moment of shock, the loyal First Mate straightened at once. “Yes, Captain!”

…

The churning sea around them slowly calmed. Only the sound of waves remained.

The deafening roar of the cannons still echoed in Duncan’s mind, making him unconsciously scratch his ear. He clearly had not yet adapted to that sudden encounter.

Goathead’s voice sounded in his ear: “Just now you headed straight for the Sea Mist at full speed. I thought you wanted to say a few words to Tyrian. After all… this counts as a very meaningful ‘reunion’.”

“That was what I planned at first,” Duncan answered casually. “I just changed my mind all of a sudden.”

“Why?”

“…After meeting him, I suddenly realized I didn’t know what to say,” Duncan said openly. Since he and Goathead had already had that ‘lay-it-all-out’ talk, he no longer spoke as carefully as before. “We are not close.”

“…All right, whatever you say,” Goathead had no objection. “But you should still think about how you plan to get along with your two ‘children’. Everyone here tends to live a long time. You will have to meet them sooner or later. A good family relationship has a huge impact on fate. Back in the day, there was someone who…”

“Shut up.” Duncan cut off the wandering topic with practiced ease. Then, as if he suddenly thought of something, his expression turned a bit strange. “Come to think of it, it’s a pity we were missing someone on the ship this time.”

Goathead hesitated. “Missing someone? You mean…”

“Alice wasn’t here. She is back in the city minding the shop,” Duncan said in a relaxed tone, even with a hint of amusement. “I suddenly remembered that Tyrian once served under the Frostholm Queen for a time. Alice is walking around with the Frostholm Queen’s face.

“Imagine if Alice had been on the ship just now. That would have been interesting. I bet Tyrian would spend days thinking it over after he went back…”

“…”

“Why did you go quiet? Aren’t you usually very talkative?”

“I am not in a position to comment on your family matters…” Goathead replied. “But after hearing you say that, I also think that scene would have been worth seeing… Why don’t we turn back and make another trip? This time we bring Miss Alice along…”

Of course, Duncan ignored that ridiculous suggestion. He stayed silent for two seconds, then suddenly said, “Didn’t see it before, but you really are in it for the laughs.”

“What does ‘in it for the laughs’ mean?”

Duncan did not answer. He simply lifted his head and looked toward a certain spot on the distant sea.

Just now, for an instant, he had clearly sensed the body he left in the city-state of Pland through the Vanished, and had even felt the flames spreading

through the city.

It matched his earlier guess. Once the distance was close enough, the connection between the Vanished and Pland… grew stronger.

Chapter 209: Mortal Realm Invasion

The stormy rain had not stopped. It even showed signs of growing worse. Wild winds drove the cold rain against the tall outer walls and stained-glass windows of the Deep Sea Grand Cathedral, like the heavy, chaotic heartbeats of the city-state.

On the square in front of the city, Steam Walkers and Steam Tanks had already assembled. Fully armed Guardians silently blocked every street.

On the bell tower at the back of the Grand Cathedral, a special brazier had been lit. Purified Whale Oil mixed with chips of Sea-Breath Wood burned fiercely in the basin. In the storm, the flame shone like a lighthouse guiding ships home. Special focusing lenses strengthened the light, so that the bright flame could be seen clearly from most of the city-state.

As the central Grand Cathedral's brazier flared to life, similar flames appeared above cathedrals all across the city. Even in the most remote neighborhood cathedrals, there was a tall bell tower facing the Grand Cathedral from afar. At the top of each of those towers, a brazier waited in its place.

On this dark, stormy day, bell tower after bell tower lit up, forming a chain of lighthouses over Pland. When all the lights came on, clear bells and loud steam whistles rang out across the entire city-state.

Every Cathedral's boilers fired up. Every Cathedral's bells rang. Pland roared in the storm, as if civilization itself were standing in the darkness,

resisting some invisible invading force.

This strange situation made all the residents shut their doors and windows tight. Those who knew more about the supernatural field could sense the danger of the moment from this citywide upheaval of the Cathedrals.

Deep inside the governor's residence, Dante Wayne had just woken from unconsciousness when he heard the waves of bells and whistles outside. He also saw the many "lighthouses" near and far in the darkness. With the help of an attendant, he sat up and stared in shock at the apocalyptic scene through the glass window.

"The Grand Cathedral has activated the Mortal Realm Stabilization Barrier… Is this a Mortal Realm invasion-level disaster?!"

"We are still investigating," an aide hurried to his bedside, his tone a bit tense. "It came very suddenly. The Grand Cathedral only said that all districts of Pland must enter a Highest-Level Lockdown. You were unconscious at the time, so Bishop Valentine used emergency authority…"

Dante did not reply. He suddenly seemed to sense something. His brows slowly relaxed.

"…Vanna is back."

"Miss Vanna?" The attendant at his side turned with a confused look. "Miss Vanna did not return to the residence. She should…"

"I know." Dante knew the others could not understand his sudden words, so he waved his hand. His gaze finally settled on the aide. "Is the city's Guard Corps still under City Hall command?"

"Yes. Bishop Valentine only took direct control of the constable forces and some of the Guard Corps tasked with emergency response," the aide said at once. "Most of the Guard Corps are still waiting for your orders."

“Good. Aside from the First Division, put all units of the Guard Corps under the Grand Cathedral’s arrangements,” Dante said. His head still felt hazy, but his orders came fast. “Also, the whole city enters Highest-Level Martial Law. Ring all the Martial Law Bells. After the bells ring, anyone found on the streets—anyone at all—will be treated as a cultist.”

The aide was shocked by this order. “Mr. Dante, this…”

“Carry out the order.” Dante lifted his head. His one remaining eye was sharp. The skin around the ruby prosthetic eye on the other side once again seeped thin lines of blood. “We are now in a state of war.”

“…Yes!”

The aide took the order and left. Dante then broke into a harsh cough. Only after a long moment did the coughing ease a little. He spoke in a low voice to the attendant beside him: “Take me to the Grand Cathedral.”

“Mr. Dante, your body…”

“My body is not important. I have something important to tell Bishop Valentine.”

“Yes.”

…

Nina gripped Shirley’s hand and sat behind the shop window, shaking as she watched the wild wind and pouring rain outside. Thunder boomed again and again in the sky, making all the doors and windows rattle.

The scene was so frightening that even Shirley, who was usually very brave, started to tremble. She could not help muttering under her breath: “What the hell kind of weather is this…”

“Shirley, you… you can’t swear,” Nina said, face tense even though she was scared. “Uncle said you…”

“Okay, okay, I won’t swear, I won’t swear. Just don’t tell Mr. Duncan,” Shirley said quickly. Then, out of the corner of her eye, she suddenly noticed a figure on the stairs and shrank her neck on reflex. “Ah, Mr. Duncan is coming down.”

“Uncle Duncan!” Nina jumped to her feet at once and almost ran toward the figure coming down the stairs. “You… you finished your work?”

“Yes. I’m done for now, but things are not over yet,” Duncan said. He casually pressed a hand on Nina’s hair, then turned toward the counter. Morris still sat there, but his face already looked a bit better. Duncan nodded to him. “I have brought her back.”

“I just felt it. She came back,” Morris said at once. “I still don’t know how you did it, but… thank you very much for your help.”

“This is only the beginning. It’s too early to thank me now,” Duncan said as he turned his head to look out the shop window. “The plot was exposed. They have already started their move ahead of time. The intruders are attacking on the other side of the Veil… They will probably arrive very soon.”

Morris looked deeply worried. Nina looked at Duncan in confusion. “Uncle, what intruders? You mean…”

“Nina.” Duncan cut the girl off. He turned toward her, his expression more serious than she had ever seen. “Do you trust me?”

Nina almost did not hesitate. “I trust you.”

“Good. Then hold on to the belief that this storm will end safely. No matter what happens later, do not panic. No matter what I do, don’t get nervous, don’t be afraid,” Duncan said, looking into Nina’s eyes. Then he raised his hand and pointed at Alice, who was standing quietly by the stairs. “Alice can be trusted. If there is a real emergency, stay with her.”

Nina nodded in a daze. Alice spoke at once: “Please rest assured, Mr. Duncan. I will protect Miss Nina.”

“I really don’t have much faith in your fighting skills,” Duncan said, giving Alice a look. Then he sighed helplessly. “But there is no one else I can trust her to.”

Another clap of thunder exploded overhead. From somewhere out on the street came the crash of something falling down. Along with the crash came a sharp alarm from some unknown place and the urgent ringing of Cathedral bells farther away.

The lights in the antique shop flickered a few times, then went out.

The power went down.

Darkness fell over the whole street at once. It was as if the neighborhood had entered the veil of night early in the middle of the storm.

In the gloom, Shirley’s voice came from not far away: “I’ll light the oil lamp! I know where it is!”

Duncan answered with a soft sound, but suddenly, he felt Nina grab his hand.

Her hands felt a bit hot.

“Uncle…” Nina said in a tense, rapid whisper. Even her breath carried a faint heat. “I feel… a little hot…”

In the darkness, Duncan’s gaze turned serious at once.

But aside from that seriousness, he showed no extra panic.

From the very beginning, he had been ready for any sudden change in Nina’s condition.

He simply held Nina’s hand more firmly as it grew hotter and hotter. Between their fingers, in gaps that the eye could hardly catch, tiny ghostly green sparks flickered.

He heard the flap of wings. The pigeon AI flew down from upstairs in the dark and landed neatly on the counter.

Shirley lit the oil lamp. The wavering flame drove away the darkness in the shop for now, but outside on the street, the sky was already black as ink. The light and power of the Sun had been completely blocked by the storm outside the city-state.

“Nina, do you remember what I told you just now?”

In the dim light, Duncan’s voice reached Nina’s ears.

Nina nodded lightly. “Yes.”

“Don’t be afraid later. There will be some… very powerful things happening.” Duncan smiled and spoke softly.

Out of the corner of his eye, he looked farther away.

Outside the window, on the rain-soaked street, the falling sheets of water had begun to pick up an unnatural red tint. The red color was bright and flickering, like a reflection from another time and space cast upon the Mortal Realm.

But Duncan did not stare at the now-unusual rain, nor did he pay attention to the “reflections” coming through the Veil.

His gaze passed over the uneven buildings of Pland and the coast. He looked toward the Boundless Sea.

The ghostly silhouette of the Vanished slowly appeared in his pupils.

…

Heidi flinched the moment the thunder cracked.

She was curled up on a long bench in the main hall of the Grand Cathedral, both hands gripping the crystal pendant at her neck like an Amulet. She quietly recited the holy name of the God of Wisdom, Rahm, but stopped halfway through the benediction and lifted her head to look at the statue of the storm goddess.

“The Goddess is kind… she shouldn’t mind.”

She muttered under her breath, then went back to reciting Rahm’s name.

All at once, she stopped again. A strange thumping in her chest made it impossible to focus.

Heidi rose from the bench and looked around in that sudden unease.

She saw the Guardians gathered near the main doors. A small group of commoners who had not made it home in time and had come to the Cathedral for shelter sat on the benches before the statues. Several priests moved about the hall. Bishop Valentine stood before the statue with his staff, calm gaze fixed straight ahead.

Everything looked normal. So where was this feeling of dread coming from?

Without her noticing, the crystal pendant at her neck had begun to grow warm. But Heidi seemed not to care about that. She walked on instinct to a nearby window and looked out through the clear pane beside the stained glass at the scene in the square.

The young psychiatrist’s eyes went wide.

“Fire… fire!” she cried out in fear. “The rain has turned into fire!”

Chapter 210: Rain of Fire

The rain turned into fire.

Heidi cried out, and that seemingly illogical scream was the only description she could think of in that moment. She simply could not understand what she was seeing, could not understand what had happened. She only knew that a torrential Rain of Fire was falling from the sky.

It all happened in an instant.

The downpour that covered Pland transformed in a heartbeat into flames pouring down from above. It was like a fallen sunset, like an inverted corona. In less than a second, the whole city-state changed from a storm-battered city into the vision of a city melting in living fire.

Everything was set ablaze: trees, houses, towers, clock towers. Even the ground itself spewed fire. The rainwater running along the streets turned into searing lava. The deafening thunder turned into explosions all across the city-state. Those blasts came from steam pipes, gas lines, and pressure vessels bursting one after another in a short time. The roar was even more terrifying than the thunder before… the whole Grand Cathedral shook violently.

Heidi stumbled back in terror as she watched an ending of utter destruction directly overlap the Mortal Realm itself. Then she heard a tolling bell.

The sound seemed to pass through a thick barrier, as if it came from very far away. It was the steam clock tower behind the Grand Cathedral, ringing the Great Bell.

The loud and solemn tolling broke through the Rain of Fire. Right after that, more bell sounds came, near and far, from deep within the fiery rain.

The Cathedral matrix of Pland rang with a hundred bells at once. The Mortal Realm stabilization barrier activated in response. Under the tolling, the torrential Rain of Fire seemed to suffer some invisible disturbance. The flames falling over the Cathedrals turned back into ordinary rain. Even the burning spires and banners of the Grand Cathedral returned to normal in the blink of an eye.

The whole city of Pland burned, yet all the Cathedrals withstood the falling fire under the bell tolls. The bizarre rainstorm and the even stranger sea of fire mixed together in a grotesque way over the burning land. Each Cathedral became like a lonely island in a purgatory, holding firm as a chain of anchors amid the upheaval of heaven and earth.

Only then did Heidi finally hear a steady, aged voice behind her. Bishop Valentine broke the silence and said: “The enemy has launched the attack… Destroy every target that tries to approach the Cathedral bell towers!”

Heidi turned her head. She had just opened her mouth to ask something when a series of deafening explosions suddenly came from the plaza outside the Cathedral.

She ran to the window and saw the Guardian troops assembled in the plaza opening fire. The Steam Walkers’ rotary machine guns were spraying bullets toward the distant streets. The main guns of the Steam Tanks fired again and again. The units hastily transferred from the city-state’s Guard Corps had already set up fortifications at the edge of the rain and were pouring fire at something in that sea of flames.

Heidi finally saw the enemy.

They were writhing Ashen Humanoids, endless in number, crawling and squirming out of the fire. Just looking at them made her blood run cold.

Those ashes seemed to emerge from the flames out of thin air. The shifting forms shrieked and screamed in pain every second. They surged in from all directions, like beasts drawn by some strange lure, rushing toward every Mortal Realm stabilization Node in the city-state—the Cathedral bell towers.

The warriors fired in confusion. Most of them had no idea why this battle had begun or what had happened to their familiar home. They did not even dare think about where those disturbing “enemies” came from. But their duty as the city’s Guards, their trained obedience, and their will to survive pinned them to that infernal frontline. They fought by pure muscle memory, drilled a thousand times over.

So the Guard troops’ guns and cannons roared, easily ripping apart the first wave of ashes that swarmed toward them.

But the next second, more ash rose behind the scattered remnants. Even more twisted, burned things came with the flames and smoke, surging toward the Cathedral.

Their numbers were as if they equaled the entire population of the city-state.

“Hold the bell towers.” Valentine’s voice suddenly rang out, echoing over the whole Cathedral plaza and even above the entire city-state. “As long as the bells are still ringing, our Mortal Realm will not be altered and overwritten by them! Believers, the time has come to witness your faith… Hold the bell towers!!”

In the midst of the chaos, Heidi watched everything, feeling as if her world had already fallen apart. But after a short moment of adjustment, she forced

herself to calm down. Once she realized this was a full-scale Mortal Realm invasion, she forced herself not to look at the sea of flames beyond the plaza, not to think about the “fact” that ninety percent of the city-state had already been effectively destroyed. Instead, she ran straight to Bishop Valentine and said: “Is there anything I can do to help?”

“Calm the commoners sheltering in the Cathedral. We must avoid anyone inside the Cathedral having a mental breakdown,” Valentine said in a deep voice. “Then wait with them until this storm passes.”

Heidi nodded at once. But just then Valentine suddenly lifted his head, as if his gaze pierced the tall walls of the hall and looked over the distant city.

Flames and flashes were reflected in the archbishop’s eyes. A bird’s-eye view of the entire city-state appeared in his sight.

He clearly saw all of Pland burning fiercely under the Rain of Fire. Each Cathedral became an island in the sea of flames. Every Cathedral suffered an invasion from beyond the Mortal Realm. Blazing Evil Spirits, released from some branch of Doomsday, were attacking the still-ringing bell towers in a frenzy, as if desperately trying to drag this surviving Mortal Realm world down into the same tragic End as their own. Behind those ashes stood countless Tall Gaunt Shadows.

Those dark figures stood silently in the fire, wordlessly pushing the city-state toward Doomsday.

They were the minions of the Sunspawn.

The minions of the Sunspawn?

Valentine’s expression suddenly shifted. Faced with this massive disaster at the level of a Mortal Realm invasion, he suddenly remembered a “small matter” that had supposedly been resolved long ago and nearly forgotten.

He turned sharply to a High Deacon at his side and said: “Are those Sun heretics still in the underground sanctum?!”

“The Sun heretics?” The High Deacon did not react at first. He stared blankly for a second before answering in a hurry: “Yes, they are still locked in the underground sanctum. A full Guardian battalion is on watch. They cannot escape…”

“They never planned to escape from the start!” Valentine said quickly. “From the very beginning, they wanted to be locked inside the Cathedral!”

“Wha…”

The High Deacon’s eyes went wide. Before he could finish, a dull boom suddenly came from deep beneath the Cathedral.

It was as if some giant beast had awakened in the underground sanctum.

Some priests in the Grand Cathedral who had lived through a certain Sun crisis four years ago thought of something else when they heard that boom.

Four years ago, hundreds of Sun heretics had gathered in their hiding place and, through a mad and bloody sacrificial rite, summoned a short-lived but terrifying forbidden power. A “replica Sun” formed underground and almost caused a catastrophe.

But before they could succeed, their plot had been discovered by the newly promoted Inquisitor Vanna, who led a team to wipe them out.

“…That was a test…”

The High Deacon stared, muttering to himself.

Heidi felt the heat around her suddenly rise and sensed the tremors from deep underground growing stronger and stronger.

Fire surged. Bells rang as one. Steam whistles shrieked through the Rain of Fire. Countless ash-born monsters appeared from all directions and rampaged across the mortal world.

Vanna had lived through many dangerous battles. She had faced cultists, forbidden monsters created by cultists, runaway Abyssal demons, and deranged, raving Enders. Yet no battle could compare to this purgatory before her.

She was no longer facing a battlefield, but a suddenly descended Doomsday.

Or rather, Doomsday had already come long ago. It had only been hidden behind the Veil until this day. Now someone had torn the Veil away—the living had no time to react before they became embers in Doomsday.

But Vanna was still alive. She had carved a bloody path through fire and ash and was struggling toward the towering Grand Cathedral at the center of the city-state.

Every breath burned her lungs. Her body was so exhausted it could have crushed an ordinary person several times over. Her armor was badly damaged. Her body's recovery could no longer keep up with the rate of harm. Her wounds grew worse bit by bit.

Yet the young Inquisitor still moved forward.

The bells of the Grand Cathedral were still ringing. That meant Bishop Valentine's defenses had not yet been broken. Perhaps the Guardians did not know the history of this corruption or the full conspiracy behind it, but they had always prepared for every conspiracy and battle.

As long as the battle at the Grand Cathedral continued, Vanna believed she had a duty to return to her place on that battlefield.

Vanna thought as she moved.

She noticed that Bishop Valentine had activated the Mortal Realm stabilization measures, which meant he had already realized part of the truth. At least that part of their response was correct. As long as the bell towers did not fall, the heretics' scheme to overwrite "true history" with a "false history" would not succeed so easily.

As long as the overwriting process was interrupted in the end and the corruption cut out from history at its source, the city-state could still be saved. The current destruction was not true destruction. It was only a terrifying "possibility" created by two different histories overlapping… It was not too late. It was still not too late.

Vanna repeated this in her heart as if she were cheering herself on. She tried not to think about the possibility of the other Cathedrals falling. She tried not to think about where that mysterious and terrifying Captain Duncan might be waiting along this chain of events. She only moved her feet in a mechanical rhythm, smashing every obstacle in her path and walking step by step along the burning streets, closing the distance between herself and the Grand Cathedral.

But suddenly, she stopped at an intersection not far from the Grand Cathedral.

A dark gray car had flipped and lay upside down by the roadside, as if it had overturned in an accident on its way to the Grand Cathedral. Several bodies lay dead nearby, thrown from the car.

There was still someone inside the car. An arm stuck out of the tilted window, trapped against the twisted door.

Vanna recognized the car at once, and she recognized that arm.

It was her uncle, Dante Wayne.

Chapter 211: divine blessing

That familiar car lay overturned in the street, as if it had crashed on the way to the Grand Cathedral. Vanna's uncle was clearly still inside. Her already hazy mind tightened in an instant. In the blink of an eye she rushed to the car.

Then she saw that the arm hanging out of the window was twitching slightly. The blood-soaked hand seemed to rise just a little as she drew near.

Her uncle was still alive.

Vanna reacted at once. She hurried forward, braced the car with one hand, and snapped the twisted door frame with the other. Then she leaned in, propping up the warped structure while she checked Dante's injuries. She pulled her uncle out of the car as carefully as she could, trying not to cause any further harm. Right after that, she cast divine magic. With the last of her strength, she called upon the Blessing of the Sea Breeze, trying to bring life back into Dante's fading body.

The almost suffocating hot wind still raged through the streets. Burning ash and falling sparks made the city-state look like a literal hell. Vanna held a Protective Ward around herself, its powerful pressure forcing back the deadly environment nearby. She laid Dante flat on the ground. After a round of desperate efforts, she finally saw the man who had raised her for eleven years slowly open his eyes.

"Ah… Vanna… you came back…"

That was the first thing Dante said when he opened his eyes.

“Yes, I came back,” Vanna answered at once. She did not notice what was strange about that word “came back”. She simply reached out and took his hand. “How do you feel? Can you still move? I’ll take you to the Grand Cathedral…”

“No… Don’t bother with a burden like me,” Dante shook his head slightly. He tightened his grip on Vanna’s hand, his fingertips pressing weakly. “I should have known this day would come… They came to claim the price… You have to go. Before they find you… leave Pland. Go somewhere no one knows you…”

Hearing her uncle’s whisper, Vanna froze. She suddenly realized that her uncle seemed to know something even she did not. Her voice trembled a little: “What do you mean? Who are ‘they’? What price are they taking? Did you… already know what was happening in the city-state?!”

Dante forced his eyes open. The ruby prosthetic eye he had worn was shattered, and blood ran down from the wounds at the edge of his eye socket. In his remaining human eye, the endless fires on the street were reflected. After a few seconds of silence, he finally spoke in a low voice: “The Enders… and the Subspace behind them… Vanna, do you remember the great fire eleven years ago?”

“The great fire eleven years ago…” Vanna’s eyes widened a little. “You actually remember that fire?”

“How could I not remember… It burns in front of my eyes every day,” Dante said with a bitter smile. “I just thought I could lie to myself for the rest of my life.”

Chaos boiled in Vanna’s mind. In that moment she seemed to forget her exhaustion and wounds. She stared at her uncle’s already clouding eye and thought of everything she knew about the fire, the Black Sun, the Subspace, and the Enders. Before all those clues buried her, she finally asked: “But

what does that have to do with the Subspace and the Enders… and with me? What connection do I have to all this? Why are ‘they’ coming for me? What ‘price’ do they want to take?!”

Right after she poured out the questions, Vanna regretted her tone. It sounded less like she was talking to her uncle and more like she was interrogating a criminal. But Dante seemed not to care. He only took a few shallow breaths and then spoke again, his voice like a dream: “When that fire started, I caught a glimpse of… a thin projection of the Subspace. When that extreme and dangerous Truth arrived, I made a wish to the Subspace.”

“You made a wish to the Subspace?” Vanna stared at Dante in shock. “What wish?”

“I wished that nothing had happened. I wished that you… would come back to life.”

Every expression on Vanna’s face froze.

Dante silently gazed at his niece. His face looked as if he were crying, yet there was a bitter smile mixed into it. He slowly raised his hand, as if he wanted to touch Vanna’s hair. His lips moved, and he said in a low voice: “Vanna… you’ve grown up… I’m sorry, I really am. Your uncle was useless. Back then… I didn’t manage to save you…”

“But I remember you taking me out of that fire…”

“I only carried a little pile of ash out of the burning house,” Dante said quietly. “It happened in just an instant. There was no time to react. You turned into this tiny bit of charred ash… I went mad trying to escape that nightmare, trying to make everything go back to how it was before the disaster. I begged for help from anyone who could grant it, a deity, a demon, even the Subspace itself… And then, something answered my wish.

It took me many years to understand what exactly had answered me in that moment…”

Vanna seemed to no longer hear the rest of Dante’s words.

She slowly raised her hands and looked at her own body of flesh and blood.

She did not know how long passed before she finally broke the silence: “So, in a certain sense, my survival is the result of the Subspace’s divine blessing?”

Dante closed his eyes a little. He could not answer the question. He could only agree in silence.

“Then… how did I become a Saint?” Vanna asked at once. She was asking her uncle, but it also sounded as if she were asking herself. “How would the Storm Goddess allow someone who survived thanks to the Subspace’s divine blessing to become Her believer, and even grant such great power and protection?”

“I… I don’t know,” Dante said, shaking his head slowly. “Maybe only the Goddess Herself can answer that question, but… how could we ever…”

Vanna did not reply. Her thoughts were in greater turmoil than ever. The faith that had supported her all these years now showed a crack that could not be bridged. She did not know how to face her belief, or even how to face her own ‘existence’. Yet after a short silence, she still rose to her feet and said softly, almost to herself: “No matter what, someone has to stop this Mortal Realm invasion. We must… bring back the world we know as the Mortal Realm.”

“Vanna, you will die,” Dante said suddenly, his eyes snapping open. He used all his strength to push himself upright. “You cannot stay here. The foundation of this Mortal Realm is breaking apart. You must leave Pland, leave this manifestation, until it disappears from your memory completely.

Listen, if your survival really is the result of the Subspace's divine blessing, then correcting history may cause you to turn back into dust. That kind of paradoxical clash isn't something a mortal can…"

Vanna only gazed quietly at her uncle. Her eyes were gentle and calm.

"Uncle, didn't you say you loved this city-state and everything in it?"

Dante was silent for a moment. Then the firm expression returned to his face: "…Of course. So I will stay here and face fate together with this city, whether I live or die in the end. I'm ready. But… but you are different, Vanna. You can't…"

"I'm the same," Vanna said lightly, cutting him off. "I love this place too, and I am ready for everything… just like you taught me when I was small. Duty above all."

Dante quietly looked at Vanna standing before him, at the only family he had left in this world. Her figure was as tall as ever, steady and firm, like a seawall ready to meet a giant wave.

He knew his words would have no more effect.

So he let out a soft sigh. With the last of his strength, he shifted himself and leaned against a nearby lamppost.

"Go, then," he said softly. "I'll stay here… and wait for you to come back."

Vanna lowered her head and looked at her uncle.

In her memories, her uncle was still a tall, unwavering mountain. When had he become so much shorter than she was?

She bent down slightly and spoke in a low, gentle voice: "…If everything goes well, the Pland you know will return to the Mortal Realm. When that happens… don't forget me."

Dante did not answer. He only nodded slightly.

Vanna straightened up.

The next moment, an unsettling tremor came from far away and cut her movement short. Right after that came a terrifying explosion and the tooth-grinding screech of buildings tearing apart and collapsing.

Vanna looked in shock toward the source of the sound. She had never felt such fear and unease as she did now. In the next second, what she saw confirmed the source of that dread.

From the direction of the Grand Cathedral, a pillar of flame shot up into the sky. The blast wave almost tore apart the hot smoke clouds high above. A blinding, unnatural flash followed, as if a small Sun were rising from underground, ready to rise from below and melt everything to nothing.

Then something even worse happened.

She heard more explosions and more shrieking noise. She saw pillar after pillar of fire rise from all parts of the city-state. Huge fireballs floated above the sea of flames like small Suns. Each fireball rose from the location of a Cathedral.

The bells, which had never stopped ringing even during the city’s melting, finally fell quiet. The sheltered islands within the city began to fall one after another.

Vanna felt her mind go blank. The next second, driven by instinct, she rushed toward the source of the greatest light burst, toward the Storm Grand Cathedral at the heart of Pland.

Chapter 212: Diverging Paths – The End

All the Cathedrals fell in a short time. One blazing “fireball” after another rose from underground all across the city-state, burning away Pland’s last anchors to the Mortal Realm. The bells fell silent one after another. In only a few moments, this Sea Jewel had nothing left but endless ruins and ash.

Vanna rushed through burning intersections and streets like a storm, heading toward the Cathedral in her sight, the one crowned by a pillar of fire reaching into the sky. Yet in her eyes, the Cathedral had already changed in that short time—

The main building had collapsed. The thousand-year-old frame of the structure had melted and sagged like wax. The tall side wings had, in the blink of an eye, turned into twisted, red-hot skeletons.

Above all this, a Sun hung quietly in the air over the great Cathedral. Its edge shone white, but inside it was dark, black-red like dried blood. It looked like a horrible, hollow opening into an endless abyss, yet it kept releasing destructive light and heat.

Along the edge of this blasphemous Sun Wheel, bright red drops of liquid kept flowing and falling—molten lava, or perhaps the blood of the blasphemers.

Now what could she do by rushing over there? Kill some mastermind? Reverse the history that had already overlapped? Or use all her strength to die bravely yet uselessly, proving her own faith and loyalty at the very end?

Vanna did not know. She did not know what else she could do. But she still ran toward the Cathedral on instinct.

Just then, something twisted and ghostly green flashed at the edge of her vision, as if something flickered through the sea of fire. A stern, deep voice rang directly in her mind: “Go to the Great Bell tower.”

The voice came so suddenly that Vanna stopped on reflex. She searched for the source of the sound, or for any trace around her that might prove the ghost captain was turning his gaze toward her.

But all she saw was roaring fire. Molten drops from that blasphemous Black Sun fell down, igniting the last inch of ground near the great Cathedral.

At that moment, another sound broke her brief hesitation.

She heard a bright, long peal of bells suddenly ring out—the sound came from the ancient bell tower behind the Cathedral.

The bell rang so loud it seemed ready to cover all of Pland again.

But that bell tower had already been burned through by fire. It should not have been able to make any sound at all.

At that moment, Vanna dropped all doubts and worries in her heart and ran toward the bell tower.

She no longer cared what intention the ghost captain had, or what consequence might come from following his directions. With all the Cathedrals falling in an instant, with the whole city-state already burned down, the only path left for her was the bell tower that still rang.

She crossed the plaza in front of the Cathedral.

The defense forces that had once assembled on the plaza were completely wiped out. In the rolling waves of heat, she could only see countless twisted, ruined steam walkers and steam tanks. The defense line that

Guardians and the Guard Corps had formed had become layers of charcoal, all buried under shocking ash.

She cut down countless ash shadows that swarmed at her, then passed through the Cathedral's main hall and sanctuary, which had already burned into ruins. She crossed the wide-open courtyard and saw the bell tower standing high at the end of her sight.

Hot ash fell from the sky. Sparks flew like fireflies.

It made her remember what she had seen not long ago on the other side of the Veil, the Pland she had seen that was burned down by fire in 1889.

False history had covered true history. What lay behind the Veil had replaced the Mortal Realm world in front of the Veil.

But the bell still rang.

The door leading into the upper levels of the bell tower had collapsed. The stairs inside had broken and fallen away. After seeing this, Vanna gave up on climbing the tower by the normal path. She came to the foot of the bell tower's outer wall, lifted her head to quickly pick a route, then reached out and grabbed the protruding stonework, climbing straight up.

The outer wall had been baked by fire for a long time. It was as hot as a red-hot iron plate. But Vanna's climbing speed did not slow at all. She swept upward like a gust of wind. In only a brief moment, she reached the upper part of the bell tower, crossed the stopped clock face, and stepped onto the top of the tower where the bonfire and the Great Bell were placed.

The top was broad. A pointed roof open on all four sides gave some cover. Under that roof, besides the fire basin, stood the bell-striker mechanism—a huge machine of gears and levers.

The Great Bell hung under this machine, hidden inside a resonance chamber.

Vanna vaulted onto the top of the tower and landed.

She looked back toward the way she had come and saw the city-state beneath her sinking into a sea of fire. Scorching lava flowed down the streets, leaving shocking ravines behind. From this height above the city, she looked down on a living hell and saw only ruin.

Then she turned back toward the bell-striker mechanism, which clearly had lost all power, yet still kept moving.

A figure—or rather, a clump of charcoal barely keeping a human shape—was clinging to the lever beside the bell-striker mechanism, using the last of his strength to keep the heavy gears turning.

Vanna stepped forward on reflex. The charcoal figure seemed to feel her coming closer. He slowly lifted his head and turned his face. A pair of human eyes looked at the young inquisitor who had appeared on the top of the tower.

“Hold… the tower…”

The charcoal figure rasped in a hoarse voice.

Then he crashed to the floor. His completely carbonized body broke apart. The last heat faded from the rubble of his remains, and the glowing red cracks on his body slowly went out.

A Storm Emblem, symbol of the Deep Sea Church, rolled out of the pile of charcoal and onto the ground.

Pland’s last bell finally fell silent.

“Archbishop!”

Vanna recognized those eyes. She rushed forward, wanting to save that heap of ash, or to push the bell-striker mechanism again herself. But just as she took her first step, a sudden, crushing pressure forced her to stop.

Vanna froze in place by sheer will and turned toward the direction that pressure came from.

A tall, thin figure in a ragged gray robe, body shriveled and dry like an ascetic monk, stood quietly at the edge of the platform.

The “monk” looked at Vanna with pity in his eyes. Behind him, in the sky, hung the Black Sun, its edge blazing bright, its body dripping molten fire.

Vanna did not know when he had appeared there. His arrival was so silent that she had not sensed it at all. It was as if he had been standing on this high tower from the very beginning, from long, long ago—even before the fire started.

“You have struggled with all your strength, child. You all have. You even delayed things several times longer than expected. But this delay and this defense have no meaning. No one will come to save you. In this already closed-loop historical Vision, any reinforcements are fated never to reach Pland before history correction is complete…”

The thin, black figure spoke slowly. He lifted his hand a little. His bony arm seemed to shimmer with flame in the light of the Black Sun behind him. “Now, embrace this new future. Rise from the ashes, child… your survival and return did not change anything.”

Vanna stayed silent. She simply took the greatsword from her back.

“Oh, so the talks have broken down…” The Ender saw Vanna’s action, yet his face stayed calm and full of pity. “Of course, you can easily kill me. But that has no meaning. The Sun’s spawn is already ready to welcome his descent.

“As for me, I am only a witness to this moment of the End. I will witness it now, and I will witness it again someday.

“And you… do you see that Sun?”

Vanna lifted her gaze a little. Her eyes passed the Ender and finally noticed that, deep in that blasphemous Sun Wheel, something dark was pulsing, like a forming embryo, like a heart slowly waking.

A strange unease rose sharply in her chest.

She finally realized that the crushing pressure from before had not come from the weak and thin Ender in front of her. It came from the Black Sun behind him.

Something was waking inside that Sun!

“This plan met many setbacks. A force we never fully saw kept interfering with our correction of history again and again,” the Ender said, still looking at Vanna’s eyes with that pitiful gaze, his voice low and almost hypnotic. “The disturbance it brought made some eyes, which should never have opened, notice the truth.

“You were actually only a step away from uncovering everything. Really, just one step away—but fate is like this.

“Child, fate is this unreasonable.”

He sighed with pity and slowly walked forward. He came to stand in front of Vanna, who still stood firm. Like he was reading out a sacred Truth, he said: “But you are blessed. You have truly resurrected, and you will live and die again. You have received the highest divine blessing… so you have the chance to embrace all this.”

Vanna tightened her grip on the sword. For the first time in her life, her killing intent rose not from justice or duty, but from fierce hatred.

But in the last second before she swung, her movement was cut off by a stream of fire that suddenly burst up along the edge of the platform.

A door of ghostly green flame appeared out of nowhere behind the Ender. From it stepped a tall, majestic figure, his whole body wrapped in spirit form fire.

The Ender seemed not to notice the door behind him at all. He spread his arms, like a prophet preaching to the world before the final judgment, and declared:

“Blessed child, do not resist. As you can see, the age has changed…”

He suddenly stopped.

A nameless terror stabbed into his clouded mind. A chaotic noise, as if straight from Subspace, blended into the roaring flames of Pland.

The madman tried in panic to turn around, but before he could, a hand rested lightly on his shoulder.

“Turn back.”

A calm voice spoke.

Chapter 213: Promised Ark

“Turn back.”

At the very instant she heard these words, Vanna also heard a huge roar of noise. It was a kind of endless rumbling mixed with sharp, tearing screams inside the burning fire. It did not come from any one direction. It was like the whole city-state, even the whole world, was making that terrible sound.

Amid that skull-splitting roar, she looked toward the figure standing behind the Ender.

It was the “Captain Duncan” she had once seen in a dream. But unlike last time, what stood there now was a “ghost” completely wrapped in blazing fire, his whole body showing a vague spirit form shape.

In an instant, Vanna knew this was not his true body but another projection. Yet this time, the projection had come to the top of the tower using her as a medium. She could feel that power flowing. She felt something in her own soul burning. She felt a voice in her mind that did not belong to her.

She lifted her hands on reflex and saw faint emerald flame clinging to her body. She saw a burning path of fire spreading from under her feet. She understood. She realized that long ago, the ghost captain had already turned her into a kind of Node that could project his power.

This corruption, and the degree of this corruption, had already gone far beyond what she and Bishop Valentine had imagined. And all of it… had been for today.

In the next second, the whole world in her eyes changed at once.

ghostly green flame spread out.

In every sea of fire in Pland, in every pile of ash, in every stream of rising smoke, ghostly green flame had already been hiding for who knew how long. Now it burst out all at once, swallowing the entire city in an instant!

It happened too fast for anyone to react. Or rather, everything had already been set up long before this “Mortal Realm incursion” began. Vanna remembered the scene she had seen earlier on the other side of the Veil and suddenly realized: the great fire the Enders and the Sun heretics had made had, without anyone noticing, already become the carrier of the ghostly flame.

Their act of burning the whole city-state with fire was exactly the last step the ghost captain needed to complete the Flame Usurper!

A shrill scream suddenly rang out, snapping Vanna awake. She looked toward the source of the sound and saw that the thin, stick-like Ender was also wrapped in roaring ghostly flames. He twisted and howled at the edge of the platform like a Sacred beacon Torch.

In his melting eyes, he saw the scene of the city’s flames being seized in an instant, and he shouted curses at the curse:

“Fools! Fools! All ruined! You rejected the gift of Subspace. You will suffer forever in this world of pain… fools!!”

Yet in contrast to his curses, another scene unfolded—

Pland, which the ghostly flames burned through completely, started to recover at an unbelievable speed.

Buildings that had been burned down by fire rebuilt themselves at a rapid pace. Roads that had been melted and torn apart healed as if they were new.

The Rain of Fire falling from the sky stopped. The doomsday clouds began to fade like time itself was running backward. At the edge of the city, a corner of normal sky even appeared. And farther away…

The long-silent bells began to ring again.

Just as Captain Duncan had said: turn back.

Vanna stared with wide eyes at the impossible sight. She had never thought that a city that had been completely destroyed could really be restored. Soon, she realized what this “restoration” truly was.

The history corruption brought by the Enders and the Sun heretics was being stripped away. The false history that had fully covered Pland and replaced the Mortal Realm was being rejected and pushed out by a mighty force!

She looked in shock toward the tall figure not far away. Duncan only watched the Ender, who was almost burned into a lump of charcoal, his gaze calm. After a long time, he spoke softly, almost like to himself: “Anything can be corrupted, except Subspace…”

The Ender was still not dead. Though his body had twisted into something no longer human, a hoarse, shocked voice still came from the pile of charcoal: “You… you turned this city-state into a part of the Vanished?!”

“The Vanished is the Promised Ark. I think we can broaden the idea of an ‘ark’ a bit,” Duncan said with a smile. He bent down a little. “If a ship that meets the Vanished at sea is assimilated and absorbed, then… why can’t Pland, under my gaze, be seen as another Vanished?”

A bright peal of harbor bells rang from the distance. Vanna looked up toward the sound on reflex. The next second, she saw something that shocked her.

She saw a ship.

The Vanished appeared, sailing in from the direction of the Boundless Sea, its hull wrapped in towering spirit flame. Its half-transparent spirit form sails billowed like a Veil that covered the sky.

The ship crossed the coastline and the Harbor that was rapidly being restored. Then, as if still sailing on the sea, it moved straight into Pland, which was now full of ghostly flames. It passed grandly between the walls, houses, and towers that were being rebuilt and reset.

Ripples spread out from its sides, each wave unreal, as if it passed through another world. And every time a ripple spread, the city's restoration jumped forward again.

It looked as if the whole of Pland was being reborn in the wake of the Vanished!

"You… you may save this city-state… but you cannot stop the Sun's descent…"

A faint voice came from the twisted charcoal heap that had once been the Ender, like the last whisper before a nightmare faded. "Even a few fragments pulled back from history… are enough to destroy again… doom…"

The voice grew weaker and then vanished. The twisted charcoal finally lost its last trace of life. Under the burning of the spirit form flames, it turned into a cloud of dust and blew away on the wind.

At those words, Vanna suddenly came back to herself. She quickly raised her head and looked up at the sky.

The Black Sun still hung high above the city-state. Its edge shone blindingly bright, while its inside stayed black-red like a deep abyss. The pulsing inside the Sun was even clearer and stronger than before!

The flames of the Vanished had torn away the history corruption eating at Pland, but that blasphemous Sun had never been part of Pland to begin with. The Sun was a historical projection summoned by the Ender and the Sun's spawn together. It existed outside all true and false histories. It stood alone.

"There's something waking inside that Black Sun!"

In that moment, Vanna even forgot who she and "Captain Duncan" each were. She shouted a warning without thinking: "It will—"

But Duncan only waved a hand at her.

Then Vanna saw the ghost captain turn his body toward the blasphemous Sun Wheel in the sky. He raised his hand, as if calling or welcoming something, and spoke in a gentle voice:

"Come this way… yes, don't be afraid. You won't fall. Just come forward.

"Do you still remember how to ride a bike? Just like that… come over. I'll hold you."

In the next second, a bright golden arc of fire shot out, stinging Vanna's eyes. She saw a huge crack open along the edge of the Black Sun. An arc of flame leaped out with a joyful cheer and landed on Captain Duncan.

As that flame left, a shrill scream burst from the cursed Sun Wheel in the sky!

It was like some great beast had just taken a blow straight through the heart. The dark red core of the Sun filled with countless blazing red cracks. The bright, gleaming ring around its edge was quickly tainted and burned away by ghostly green flames. Then those flames surged inward toward the Sun's dark core.

The pulsing from that dark core stopped completely. The faint life Vanna had sensed inside vanished almost at once. The core split apart. Boiling, burning matter flowed out, but every drop was burned away by ghostly green fire before it could fall into the city.

With a storm of shrieks, roars, and crackling blasts, the twisted, blasphemous Sun finally broke apart and disappeared. Only a few scraps of residue remained, falling into the ripples around the Vanished.

By then, the huge Vanished had sailed to the center of the city. Still in spirit form, it rose higher, drifting through unreal waves and ripples until it drew near the Cathedral's bell tower. Its towering stern slid past the tower. Its spirit form sails swept across the sky. The light and shadow of masts and ropes brushed past Vanna.

She heard bells ringing. They were the Cathedral's bells.

The bell tower under her feet also broke free from the grip of corrupted history. The bell-striker mechanism started moving on its own.

Archbishop Valentine's figure slowly appeared in the air. This archbishop, who had guarded the city until the final moment, had returned to the Mortal Realm. That proved that the history branch leading toward destruction had been erased for good.

But Vanna did not keep her eyes on the archbishop. She still stared at Duncan.

Duncan had turned around. A jumping arc of flame circled at his side. The warmth and light from that flame even softened his usually shadowed, solemn face.

"I thought you were going to open with a leaping strike," Duncan said with a smile, chatting with Vanna like an old friend. "Just like last time."

"…I'm not someone who charges in without thinking."

“Really? I thought you loved leaping strikes. Every seasoned warrior finds it hard to resist starting a fight with a big jumping hit at the enemy.”

Duncan joked lightly. He reached out and soothed the arc of fire at his side, which seemed a bit restless. Then he gave Vanna a small nod and said: “I’m done here. See you next time.”

Vanna froze for a moment and stepped forward on reflex: “Wait! You can’t just—”

But Duncan had already turned away. He waved his hand and stepped off the edge of the bell tower platform into the open air.

The towering stern of the Vanished drifted slowly past the high tower. Beside the ship’s wheel on the deck stood the captain himself, steering with his own hands.

Duncan’s projection, wrapped in spirit form fire, simply stepped aboard and merged into his true body.

He stood at the helm, both hands on the wheel. He smiled and nodded once to Vanna.

The great ghost ship began to speed up. Its phantom hull sailed over Pland, riding on widening ripples of unreal water. It crossed the city to the far side of the coast and headed once more toward the Boundless Sea.

Chapter 214: After the Vanished Left

The Vanished left in the same grand, brazen way it had arrived, just as unstoppable as before.

Vanna watched the enormous ship – one could almost call it majestic – sail with solemn bearing through the center of the city-state of Pland. She watched its ghostly hull pass over the rows of rooftops and towers. The spirit form hull faded from her sight like a distant mirage. As the Vanished moved away, the spirit form flames that had been burning across Pland also began to dim and withdraw, as if they had finished some mission and were returning to nothing.

All that remained was a clear sky, a city-state that looked as it always did, and countless people who had just gone through a nightmare.

Waves of bell chimes echoed over the city-state. The bell towers of cathedrals all over the city still rang according to their original path of history. Those bells had been meant to fight off an invasion of the Mortal Realm, but now they sounded more like a farewell. The steam whistle above the Grand Cathedral also began to howl. The sharp, shrill sound made Vanna jump.

She sensed someone approaching. She turned and saw Bishop Valentine standing beside her, though she did not know when he had arrived. The old bishop, who had once passed through death itself, gripped his staff tightly.

He looked up in the direction where the Vanished had gone and spoke as if talking to himself: “I feel like I just had a very, very long dream…”

“You should know that was not a dream.”

“I mean, I just dreamed that twenty rabbits wearing Shabop dance skirts were dancing in circles around me…”

Vanna froze for a moment. “Then you really were dreaming. Maybe it happened while your mind was recovering… Did you really have to tell that bad joke right now?”

“But it did make you wake up quickly and pull your mind out of that mess and back to work,” the old bishop said calmly. His face was so steady it was as if he had not been the one making the joke. Then he lowered his head and looked toward the Cathedral square. “We have plenty to do next. This time, the one that brushed past the Vanished was not just a ship like the White Oak.”

Vanna followed the old bishop’s gaze. On the Cathedral square, the Guardians and the city’s Guard Corps were already in a kind of dazed confusion. They looked at the city, which had returned to normal, as if waking from a long dream, but their memories were still stuck in that battle when the corruption of history invaded the Mortal Realm. Some of them had “woken up” earlier and had even seen the Vanished leaving. That only made the confusion and tension worse.

Valentine’s voice sounded again beside Vanna: “…First, have the Guard troops restore order. Then we start a full survey of the whole city-state. We need to confirm whether everyone has ‘come back’, check what is missing or newly appeared in the city, and…”

Valentine paused and looked at the young inquisitor beside him.

“And prepare to report to the Storm Cathedral. Vanna, the most challenging paperwork of your life is about to begin.”

Vanna’s breath caught for a moment.

The disaster had ended, but not everything was over. Now that everyone had survived… the real investigation seemed to be only beginning.

…

The sunlight was just right.

The solemn, heavy doors of the Grand Cathedral creaked open. Heidi stepped out onto the Cathedral square with a somewhat blank look on her face. She stared at the streets that looked as ordinary as ever under the clear sky, yet in her mind there still lingered the downpour from before and the terrifying moment when that rain had turned into a Rain of Fire.

How had it ended?

She only remembered a ghost ship rising from the sea of fire and sailing through the city like it was on parade. Her mind had floated in some dimension between the Mortal Realm and illusion. Two completely different histories crossed in her sight and were split apart along the ghost ship’s path. One branch settled and became the Mortal Realm. The other was crushed to dust.

A faint burning sensation came from her chest. Heidi lowered her head and saw that the “free gift” pendant Father had brought back from the antique shop was glowing softly. She reached out to touch it. The moment her fingers brushed it, the pendant gave off a quiet cracking sound. Then, as if it had used up all its strength, it silently turned into drifting dust. Even the cord that had held it turned to ashes.

Heidi stared in a daze for a moment, but the noise rising from all over the square soon broke her trance.

The Guardians were restoring order. Garrison troops from City Hall were also taking roll and regrouping under the officers' commands at every level. Some priests came out from the Cathedral to help with the work, passing along orders from Bishop Valentine and Inquisitor Vanna. At the same time, people were talking about the silhouette of the ghost ship that had just sailed away.

"…I opened my eyes and saw that thing floating over my head, like it was sailing through clear seawater…"

"It was terrifying to look at! Those flames were almost scraping the spire of the Grand Cathedral! But it seemed to just leave…"

"That was the Vanished, no doubt about it… Don't you doubt me. That was definitely the Vanished!"

A loud voice was shouting across the square, swearing that the ghost ship that had passed through the city just now was the legendary sea calamity, the Vanished. Heidi followed the sound and saw that the speaker was an old captain with graying hair. She had dealt with this captain almost every day before, and she knew him well.

"Captain Lawrence," Heidi walked over and greeted the old captain, who was talking with a few commoners who had taken shelter. "Are you all right?"

"Me? I'm fine, even though I still don't really know what happened," the old captain said with a smile when he saw Heidi. "It's really good to see you safe too, Miss Physician. That rain and then that fire before were really scary!"

Heidi replied casually, then asked at once: "You said the ship that just left… was the Vanished?"

“Yeah, that had to be it,” Lawrence nodded at once. “I know it too well! I’ve seen that sight before!”

A citizen who had taken shelter inside the Grand Cathedral earlier and was still shaken could not help speaking up: “You’ve seen it before?”

“Of course. Why else do you think I was quarantined in the Grand Cathedral for so long?” Lawrence widened his eyes, then turned to Heidi. “I know you can talk to the higher-ups in the Church. Let me give you some advice. Later, you should carefully check what things are missing in the city. When the Vanished passes by, it usually takes something with it… I’ve got experience!”

Heidi listened in a daze and nodded just as blankly. After quite a while, memories from not long ago, yet distant as another lifetime, suddenly rose in her mind—

[How is Father?]

…

Morris did not feel well. His head was spinning, and his stomach churned like he had drunk very strong liquor. He wanted to throw up, but he did not quite dare.

Because he felt that the mops and buckets in front of him were all staring at him like predators, and Alice beside him was also silently watching him.

If he really threw up on the deck, he might get beaten up. On this ship, even any random rope was older than he was. They probably did not have the idea of respecting their elders.

He felt he was probably seasick. Or maybe pigeon-sick.

Morris lifted his head and saw the pigeon named AI strutting around the deck, inspecting the mountains of fries. Earlier, that pigeon had turned into

a terrifying Skeletal Roc and carried him onto this ghost ship when the sudden Rain of Fire fell outside the antique shop. Now it had changed back into its seemingly harmless form and was walking back and forth between the piles of fries.

The girl named Shirley was sitting not far away, with a Abyssal Hound by her side. They looked like a pair made up of a summoner and a Abyssal demon, yet right now the two of them were both on their best behavior. Shirley sat up straight like a well-bred lady and hardly dared to breathe. The Abyssal demon she called “A-Gou” had somehow found a newspaper. It sat primly on a barrel next to Shirley, trying hard to hold the paper in its paws and pretend to read it – though it clearly could not read at all, because the newspaper was upside down.

Farther away, he could see the tall masts, the gauzy, translucent spirit form sails, the boundless sea, and the city-state of Pland growing more and more distant.

When he thought back to everything he had seen and gone through while sailing with this ship through the city, Morris still felt his heart pounding. The experience of having his own body turned into a spirit form by Ghost flames, then looking down on the burning land, was a bit too thrilling. Many years ago, he might have thought it was a tense but fun adventure. But he was not young anymore. That kind of experience was now… a little too thrilling.

Morris took a shallow breath. His thoughts were a mess. He wondered whether he still had a chance to go back and worried about his family.

Just then, a voice came from across from him. It was the Abyssal Hound. Morris knew what a Abyssal Hound was, but he had never imagined one could be as calm and polite as this one: “O-old, o-old, o-old mister, do-do-

do you think I… I-I look like… like a we-well-educated, cul-cul-cultured d-d-dog?”

“Uh… To be honest, I don’t think a dog needs to read a newspaper to show that it is well-mannered. But you are a Abyssal demon, so we can’t judge you by the standards for dogs in the Mortal Realm… Besides, even the smartest dogs in the human world could never sit on a barrel and read the paper,” Morris answered, still stunned, his expression strange. “Also, two things. First, the newspaper in your paws is upside down. Second… do you have a bit of a stutter?”

A-Gou froze, then quickly flipped the newspaper around and answered: “I-I… I don’t s-stutter. I’m ju-just… a-a-a little nervous…”

“A-Gou, I don’t think you need to be this nervous,” Shirley muttered softly. “And why are you even reading the paper? Mr. Duncan already knows the two of us are illiterate…”

Before she even finished speaking and before A-Gou could answer, Alice, who had been staring off into space, suddenly raised her hand: “Me too!”

Shirley looked very surprised. Morris simply lowered his head and rubbed his forehead in silence.

The old scholar felt he had come to a place that was far too absurd. [What in the world is all this?]

Chapter 215: The Well-Behaved Sun

“Do you think… what is the situation in Pland now?”

After staying silent for a long time, Shirley finally could not hold back. She looked up at the old scholar in front of her, then at Miss Alice, who seemed very familiar with Mr. Duncan, and asked the question hesitantly.

“…I don’t know. But I think Mr. Duncan has probably already acted and solved the problem – even though I cannot imagine how he did it,” Morris said, rubbing his forehead while he thought. “More than that, right now I’m more concerned about this place…”

He lifted his head and looked around. His gaze fell on the spirit form sails above them, swelling and moving with no wind. His expression grew a bit strange.

“This ship makes me think of that legend. The one about the Vanished…”

“That’s right,” as soon as Morris finished speaking, Alice’s voice came from the side. She had a proud smile on her face. “This is the Vanished. Welcome aboard.”

Morris froze mid-rub and stared in shock. “This really is the Vanished?! Then Mr. Duncan’s identity…”

“He’s the captain, of course. Old gentleman, you are really slow,” Shirley on the opposite side curled her lips. After being nervous for so long, she finally felt a bit happy because she knew something others did not, which

made her relax a little. “He’s even called Duncan and you still didn’t figure it out?”

“You knew about this long ago?” Morris looked at the girl in front of him in disbelief. “I thought this was your first time on this ship, just like me…”

“It is my first time here – but it’s not my first time seeing Captain Duncan’s true form,” Shirley said proudly, straightening her back. “A-Gou and I have known Captain Duncan for a long time… anyway, longer than you!”

Morris did not really catch the second half of what she said. The moment he heard her mention “the captain’s true form”, he felt a twitch in his forehead. His face turned odd as he muttered, “…If possible, I would rather not know what a ‘true form’ is…”

Shirley blinked. “Huh? Old gentleman, what did you say?”

“Nothing… There are some things we should not talk about too often. It’s good for our physical and mental health.”

“Tch, say it or don’t say it. You people who do research always like being so mysterious,” Shirley muttered, curling her lips. But she did not stay quiet even for two seconds. She could not help looking toward the far end of the big ship’s deck. “Do you think… Nina is all right? She suddenly vanished in front of us, but Mr. Duncan said she only left for a little while…”

Alice’s gentle, confident voice sounded beside her, trying to comfort the worried Shirley: “Don’t worry. She will be fine.”

Shirley looked up. She was not familiar with Alice, but she knew this anomalous, beautiful and mysterious lady had been following “Captain Duncan” from an even earlier time. She must know some inside story others did not. So Shirley asked curiously: “Why do you say that? Do you know what is happening with Nina…”

“Because the captain said so,” Alice answered with a smile. “He said we don’t need to worry.”

The rest of Shirley’s words stuck in her throat.

For some reason, she suddenly felt that this especially beautiful lady in front of her seemed… not very smart…

…

At the same time, on the aft deck of the Vanished, Duncan was looking at the bright arc of flame floating in mid-air in front of him.

Now he could be one hundred percent sure that, at least in form, this arc of flame was a solar prominence. It kept repeating the process of surging out and falling back. It felt… as if someone had cut this solar prominence directly from a Sun, not only taking its existence but also taking its repeating state within a certain slice of time.

Now this “cut-out” solar prominence floated quietly on the Vanished. It even looked only as tall as a person.

But that did not mean it was truly this “small and harmless”.

Duncan could feel the amazing energy inside it. Even though he could sense only a small part, the destructive heat and the terrifying power of a star were still enough to choke him. This feeling was even stronger than the moment when he had used the Golden Mask to glimpse the Creeping Sun Wheel. It made him even more certain that this stream of flame really did come from the Sun.

It came from a real Sun – one that went beyond what those Suntists could understand, a Sun that had already mutated and broken apart in some ancient age.

This solar prominence only looked small and harmless now because it was still under control.

Duncan could not understand it. In the knowledge system he had, there was no way to explain why a part of the Sun would become like this, nor could he guess what had happened to the real star that this solar prominence had once belonged to.

Just as he could not understand this world either. He could not understand what kind of Great Annihilation could have created this strange and dangerous “Deep Sea era” they now lived in.

But in the end, he shook his head.

These things were not important for now.

Duncan took a slow breath and forced his mind to focus again. Then he carefully reached out his right hand toward the solar prominence.

A deadly heat appeared in his senses, but in the next second that heat faded like an illusion. He saw a wisp of ghostly green flame jumping at his fingertip. Inside the solar prominence, thin threads of green fire were also quietly moving, as if in resonance.

Not long ago, this bit of pre-planted corruption had ended and torn apart the birth of that Black Sun above Pland, and it had also preserved Nina’s “humanity”.

“Nina, try again,” Duncan said. “Remember how that moment of transformation felt and let yourself ‘come back’. We were very close to success just now.”

The stream of flame jumped a few times in the air. Then its surface bulged. Golden fire rose and wrapped around itself. In a short time, a figure slowly formed within the dancing light. The vague figure looked like a young maiden, but her features were still blurry.

She lowered her head, as if curiously looking at her own body. But in the next second, the newly gathered flames burst apart again, and she turned back into a surging stream of fire.

“Don’t lose heart. We will try again,” Duncan said. He was not impatient at all. He simply continued his mental guidance gently. “I will hold you up. Since you can recover to this level, it means this way is workable…”

The arc of flame swelled again. The golden fire inside crackled. Then Nina’s figure appeared from within the flames once more.

Duncan watched, a little tense. They had tried this many times already, but each attempt had failed halfway. According to the information from the spirit flame he had planted in the fragment of the Sun, this process should indeed be controllable. But clearly, this huge and unfamiliar power was not so easy to master.

The golden flames crackled. Duncan was already prepared for another failure.

But in the very next breath, the firelight and the arc of flame in front of him vanished at once.

A familiar figure jumped out from the last flicker of flame.

A gentle sea breeze blew across the deck, damp and cold. The tips of Nina’s hair lifted slightly in the wind. Bright sunlight slanted through the clouds and then through her wind-tossed hair. Between the drifting strands, the sunlight leaped and danced like tiny flames.

In the next instant, those sunlight flames dancing in her hair faded like illusions.

Nina smiled. She looked at the Uncle Duncan in front of her, who looked completely different from the one in her memory and yet was unmistakably the same: “Uncle, I’m back!”

Only then did Duncan finally let out a soft breath. As he did, the entire Vanished reacted with him. The ship seemed to have been tense this whole time, with all its ropes, masts, and sails pulled tight. Now crackling sounds rose from all directions, mixed with whooshing and clacking from under the deck.

It was as if the whole ship was cheering, celebrating together with its captain.

“Quiet,” Duncan said over his shoulder. The whole ship fell silent at once. Then he turned back and looked at Nina with some curiosity. “You can still recognize me?”

“Of course. You are Uncle Duncan,” Nina said as if it was obvious. Then she scratched her cheek – it was her habit when she was trying to hide her awkwardness and confusion. “But… I don’t even know how I knew. I just felt it was you. When I was floating in the sky before and you called me down, I also recognized you right away…”

She stopped, hesitating. She looked Duncan up and down, narrowing her eyes a little, as if she wanted to pick out some tiny details on this uncle in front of her.

He did not look like him at all. He was almost nothing like the Uncle Duncan from the antique shop.

But a clear knowing still appeared in her mind.

It felt as if she was not recognizing him with her eyes, but by directly “reading the facts”.

Nina did not know how to explain the feeling. She could only keep grinning foolishly until Duncan stepped closer and, just like always, rubbed her hair.

“That’s fine too,” Duncan said with a small sigh. “I was worrying about how to explain this ship to you, and my other appearance.”

Nina tried to dodge the hand pressing on her head. This Uncle Duncan was much taller and bigger than the one in her memory. His palm was broader and rougher too. The callused fingers brushed across her forehead and made her feel ticklish.

After a while, when he finally pulled his hand back, she suddenly lifted her head and stared straight into Duncan's eyes.

"I actually have two 'uncles'… right?"

She suddenly spoke.

Duncan did not look away. Although the question had come suddenly, he was not very surprised.

It was as if he had known long ago that this moment would come sooner or later.

If there was any power in this world that could resist "Captain Duncan's" might, then "the Sun" – no matter which Sun – was an expected choice.

He quietly met Nina's gaze.

"You noticed?"

"…Mm."

Chapter 216: the Vanished's Hospitality

The sea was calm. The breeze was pleasant. The small waves rolled gently, and the sunlight was not very strong. If one did not know what kind of Great Terror lay beneath the Deep Sea, this could even have been called a beautiful and peaceful scene.

It felt as if the terrible nightmare from not long ago, when the entire city-state had been dragged into Doomsday and burned in raging fire, had never happened at all.

On the raised platform at the stern of the Vanished, the dark helm turned by itself with no one touching it, slowly adjusting its angle. Not far away, the sails shifted bit by bit, changing their posture on their own.

Nina sat on the deck at the edge of the platform. She leaned her upper body on the rail, her legs hanging outside, swinging lightly back and forth. Duncan sat on a large wooden barrel beside her.

"…This feeling is very strange. I know you are my Uncle Duncan. I know you are someone I can rely on and trust. But at the same time, another fact is just as clear…"

She sounded as if she were talking to herself, her voice soft and slow.

"I had an uncle. He was an ordinary person. He used to be a very good man, honest and steady, hardworking. But later he became… not so good. He got sick. He started drinking, gambling, and losing his temper. Things got

worse every day. At that time, I even felt that going home was a frightening thing…

“But then suddenly, my uncle became good again, like in a dream. His health improved, his temper kept getting better, and the atmosphere at home seemed to return to how it was before. It was even better than before, really. And from then on… I often thought, if only you could really be my uncle forever, how great that would be.”

Duncan slightly frowned.

“You had already noticed back then?”

“Vaguely… but I did not dare be sure. And there is one thing I still cannot figure out.” Nina turned her head and tilted her face up a little. “If it really was the kind of Evil Spirit in the books that took over my home, then why would that Evil Spirit still treat me so well?”

Duncan looked into Nina’s eyes. After a moment, he suddenly smiled.

“I am much stronger than any Evil Spirit.”

“Now I can see that. And you are also much kinder than an Evil Spirit.” Nina smiled too, resting her head on the railing beside her, looking lazy. “You are Uncle Duncan, right?”

“Yes. And I can be that forever.”

“That is really good… I feel much better now.” Nina let out a soft breath. She fell silent for a while before she spoke again, hesitating: “My other uncle… was he calm when he left?”

Duncan remembered the night he truly stepped into the city-state of Pland.

A cultist who could no longer be saved took his last breath in a cold, damp sewer. His gloomy companions were already planning to throw the corpse

into the depths of the darkness. In his muddled mind, besides poisonous resentment, there was only twisted, fanatical worship of the Black Sun.

But a little bit of humanity still remained, and he still remembered the family member who had depended on him.

So Duncan had acted for that last bit of humanity.

“He went very peacefully. Now he should already be at rest,” Duncan said softly. “There were not many things he was still worried about at the end. You were among them.”

“That is good, then.” Nina let out a long breath, as if she had finally laid down the last of her burdens. She stretched hard, then simply leaned back and lay flat on the deck. The semi-transparent spirit form sails of the Vanished were reflected in her eyes. “So many things have happened lately, especially today… can you tell me about them? The things you have not told me yet. About this ship, about you, and… about me.”

Duncan rose from the barrel and came to lie down beside Nina. He said: “That will take a long time. Your uncle here has a lot of stories…”

…

“In short, Captain Duncan was just that amazing…”

On the wide deck of the Vanished, Alice was happily telling the Visitors about the captain’s great deeds. She had been chattering on for quite a while. At least two thirds of those deeds were things she had heard from Goathead. Those stories had first been exaggerated by Goathead, and now they had been scrambled all over again by this doll Miss, until they were twisted into something humans could barely understand. If Duncan himself heard them, he would probably jump in shock. Alice herself could not even guarantee she could repeat them correctly a second time.

Yet Shirley and Morris listened to such nonsense with great seriousness, and even Dog at the side put down his newspaper and listened with full attention.

They did not feel there was anything unreasonable in Alice's chaotic stories at all, not even when Alice firmly insisted that there were actually two huge long legs under the Vanished, and that the ship only ran so fast because it sprinted along the seabed.

When it was the big boss of Subspace, when it was the Vanished, the number one calamity on the Boundless Sea, things were supposed to sound outrageous. The more unreasonable, the more likely they were to be true.

In front of them stood Lady Alice, someone who had a place on the Vanished, who followed Mr. Duncan, and who even dared pinch Mr. Duncan's cheek back in the antique shop. What she said had to be right.

"No wonder it is the Vanished…" Morris clapped his hands in praise. He had spent his whole life studying, yet only when he listened to Alice did he realize how short his own knowledge fell. "I have seen many essays in books that study this ship. Those authors sit in their rooms and, relying on imagination alone, can write a whole book. But now it seems more than ninety percent of what they wrote is actually ridiculous…"

No sooner had the old gentleman finished speaking than a firm, authoritative voice suddenly came from the side: "I strongly advise you not to take Alice's words seriously. She is far more outrageous than those made-up books."

The moment this voice sounded, Dog shot up and darted behind Shirley. Morris quickly stood and looked toward the tall figure stepping down the nearby stairs. "Ah, Duncan… Captain, are you done?"

Duncan nodded and walked down the stairs. A small figure then followed him down.

“Nina!” When Shirley saw that figure, she jumped up and ran over in delight. “You are fine! You are back!”

As she stood up to greet Nina, the black chain wrapped around Shirley’s arm snapped tight. Dog, who had been burying his head and pretending he did not exist, was yanked forward by the chain and went tumbling and scrambling along, hopping and shouting: “Hey, slow down, slow down… hey, you are still dragging me… ow, my head…”

“Shirley.” Nina beamed, grabbed Shirley’s arm, and shook it hard twice. Then she bent down to look at Dog, whose skull had just banged into the stairs, and patted his bony head. “And you too, Mr. Dog. I am back.”

Morris also stepped forward to greet his student. Then he turned his head to look at Alice beside him and said: “Miss Alice, what you just said… you made all of that up?”

“I did not make it up! Mr. Goathead said it!” Alice widened her eyes at once. “It said it has served on the Vanished for a whole century. It knows this ship better than anyone!”

Morris looked completely puzzled. “Goathead?”

“My first mate. You will not enjoy dealing with him,” Duncan said casually. Then he let his gaze sweep over the people now standing before him.

Morris, Shirley, Dog. Unplanned passengers, Visitors the Vanished had not seen in a long time.

Back when the situation in the city-state of Pland had been critical, Duncan had already made a plan to use the Vanished’s special nature to strip away the historical corruption. But to be safe, he had still used an emergency teleportation to send the guests who had been taking shelter in the antique

shop onto this ship. Now that the troubles in the city-state had calmed down, it was time to think about what came next.

At the very least, old Mr. Morris still had family in the city-state. He would not want to stay on this ghost ship forever.

After a brief thought, Duncan withdrew his gaze.

“I think you already know where you are now, and you already know who I am,” he said. “As you can see, this is the Vanished, and I am the captain of this ship. Over the past century, at least half of the horror tales on the Boundless Sea are more or less related to me.

“I will not comment on how true or exaggerated those tales are. But there is one thing the legends do get right. Once you board the Vanished, it is very hard to cut your ties with this ship. In a sense, after going through AI’s teleportation and the Vanished’s spirit form transformation, you already count as crew members of this ship.

“Sadly, this process is both irreversible and unavoidable.”

Duncan stated this fact straight out. It was also a conclusion he had reached recently from his experiences with the Vanished and with his own power.

Those who encountered the Vanished, those who came into contact with the ghostly flame, would unavoidably form a connection with Duncan, even if he himself did not notice it. The earliest example was the White Oak. The most recent was Vanna.

Morris and Shirley reacted more calmly than Duncan had expected. Only Dog drooped his head and muttered something no one could hear.

It seemed they had already thought of this outcome and were somewhat prepared.

Duncan deliberately paused for two or three seconds, then suddenly smiled and shook his head.

“But there is one way things are different from the legends,” he said, his tone turning lighter. “This ship does not only issue one-way tickets. And as for me, the captain… as you can see, I am not really the kind of calamity in a crazed runaway state that the legends describe.

“Your boarding happened because the situation was urgent back then, so I will not restrict your freedom.”

This time, Shirley and Morris finally widened their eyes a little, especially Morris. A moment ago, the old gentleman had still been worrying over how he could possibly return to the city-state, how he could win back the right to go back to the mortal world from a Subspace shadow. He had not expected the matter to be this simple and was greatly surprised. “So… we can go back?”

“Of course you can.” Duncan smiled. “The crisis in Pland is over. You are free to come and go. But…”

Morris immediately tensed up again.

“But at least stay for a meal before you go,” Duncan said casually. “That is my way of treating guests. The food on the Vanished is simple, but it has its own special flavor. Especially the seafood. They are things you cannot get back in the city-state…”

Chapter 217: The Devout’s Doubt

Heidi suddenly let out a strong sneeze, startling the young monk who was taking notes across from her.

“Are you all right?” The young monk looked at the Miss Psychiatrist in front of him with some concern. “Are you feeling unwell? Any sense of something unusual…”

“I am fine. It was probably just the cool wind on the square just now, plus all the anxiety before. Now I have caught a chill.” Heidi waved her hand before he could finish, rubbing her nose as she spoke. “Where were we?”

“We were at the part where you saw two Mortal Realms overlapping over the city-state while you were in a state similar to Soul Departure, and how the arrival of the Vanished caused one of those Mortal Realms to be stripped away and annihilated.” The young monk glanced at what he had just written and flipped back through the earlier pages. “You also mentioned that you had a crystal pendant, and that you sensed the crystal pendant might be the key.”

“The pendant is already broken,” Heidi said after thinking for a moment and nodding. “My father got that pendant from an antique shop, but I suspect neither my father nor the shopkeeper knew anything about its special nature. It was just a free gift, even with the glass workshop’s label on it.”

“In other words, an item that had extraordinary power but hid its true form, and by chance entered the Lower City and ended up in your hands,” the

young monk said as he kept his head down and wrote. “Could you tell me about that antique shop and any detailed features of the pendant? This may help us grasp a fuller picture during the follow-up work. After all, extraordinary items often have the power to tug on fate. Your meeting with it may not have been an accident.”

“Of course, no problem.” Heidi nodded at once and began talking about what she knew. After she had finished explaining the general situation, she hesitated a little, then could not help asking: “Has everyone… come back?”

“From what we know at the moment… yes.” The young monk nodded. “Although almost everyone remembers a scene of the city-state being burned by flames, everything has now returned to how it was before the disaster. The explanation given for now by the Archbishop and the Inquisitors is an historical corruption disaster of Mortal Realm invasion level, but the detailed information still has to be made public.”

He paused and then added: “But your case is the most special. Almost no one remembers how the disaster ended, yet you saw the key process. That is why your testimony is crucial.”

“I understand.” Heidi sighed softly, then seemed to suddenly think of something. “Should I maybe send word home first to say I am safe? It looks like I will not be able to go back right away…”

“We have already sent someone.” The young monk smiled slightly. “You do not need to worry.”

“You have already notified them? Good.” Heidi thought for a moment and nodded slightly. “Then let us go on. What do you need to ask next?”

“All right. Next question. Do you remember any specific details about that ghost ship that floated between the two historical tracks? And when you

recall those details, do you experience any mental confusion, or any hallucinations of hearing or sight?”

…

Vanna came to the great cathedral.

This wide, sacred place seemed especially quiet at that moment. Aside from the necessary guards at the entrance, the hall held only Bishop Valentine, standing silently before the holy statue.

Vanna’s footsteps broke the quiet atmosphere in the great cathedral.

Valentine turned his head. He had already removed the splendid robes and crown he wore only at special times. Now he only wore a plain long robe and a soft cap. Aside from the staff in his hand that marked him as the city-state’s bishop, he looked no different from an ordinary old man.

Vanna came to stand before Valentine, her expression calm. “Order in the Cathedral district has been restored. The garrison units are returning to their posts one by one to help restore order in the city-state. The high-ranking priests have already gone to the main factories to soothe the steam cores. At least before nightfall, we can make sure the dusk Bell will ring as usual, and the gas supply for the whole city will not be interrupted.”

The old bishop clearly let out a breath of relief. “You have worked hard, Vanna.”

“It was what I should do,” Vanna said calmly. “Even after the corruption faded, the lingering mental and cognitive chaos is still having an effect. Untrained ordinary people can hardly wake up from that disaster all at once. Even City Hall is a mess right now, so for now the professionals can only take over order.”

Valentine nodded, then reminded her: “After nightfall, besides ensuring the gas supply, we also need to increase the number of night patrols in every

district. They must carry enough consecrated lanterns and incense, in case something slips in through the veil of night. We have just gone through a Mortal Realm invasion. The Mortal Realm foundation where Pland sits is in its most fragile state. We also need to check every nightfall Sanctuary World in the city one by one. Some citizens may still be so frightened that they have locked themselves inside. Once the holy oil in a Sanctuary World runs out, those panicked refugees will become a big problem."

Vanna nodded. "I understand. I will go arrange it in a bit. Tonight I will personally lead a team to inspect the key areas."

"…Just leave it to your deputy," Valentine said, looking at the young inquisitor in front of him with some concern. "Finish what you have on hand and then go rest. You are still hurt."

"My injuries have almost healed since I returned to the great Cathedral," Vanna replied at once, looking the older man up and down. "Your injuries earlier were worse than mine…"

"How could that be the same?" Valentine kept a straight face. "I have already recovered from the historical corruption. You, on the other hand, actually fought your way through the entire city-state twice in and out of the Veil. I can see how weak you are right now."

Vanna said nothing. She only turned silently, lifted her head, and under the glow of candles and gas lamps, she quietly let her gaze rest on the statue of the storm Goddess Gamona.

The great hall fell into a brief silence until Valentine broke it. "What are you thinking about?"

"I am wondering how I should write the second half of this report." Vanna sighed. "When Her Eminence the Pope wants to know about this disaster in Pland, how are we supposed to explain to her how all of this ended?"

Valentine’s expression also became rather complicated.

“In a way… well, we do not even need to say in a way.” The old bishop struggled for a long time, then could only sigh just like Vanna. “The fact is that the arrival of the Vanished extinguished the historical corruption brought by the Ender and stopped the birth of the Black Sun that was about to appear in the mortal world. Even though we do not know what that ghost captain’s purpose was in doing all this, there is no doubt…”

The old bishop stopped. After nearly half a minute of silence, he finally spoke in a low voice. “Pland survived because of the coming of the Vanished.”

“Perhaps he came for the Sun fragment.” Vanna had many thoughts in her heart, but she did not say them all out loud. “Do you still remember that ship, the White Oak? That ship faced the Vanished head on and finally got away intact, with only Anomaly 099 taken. Perhaps Captain Duncan’s goal was much simpler than everyone imagines.”

“Stealing away a Sun fragment is not the same as stealing an Anomaly,” Valentine said, shaking his head. “But you are right. This is indeed the only explanation we can think of for now. If Her Eminence the Pope wants an answer, this is the only one we can give her. The rest is to report everything that happened here truthfully and see what conclusions the priests of the great Storm Cathedral can reach.”

Vanna gave a quiet hum in reply, then turned back again, her gaze once more settling on the statue of the Goddess.

“Your heart is still very unsettled.” After knowing her for many years, Valentine could certainly sense that something was wrong with Vanna’s state. “Vanna, we have already discussed the affairs of the city-state and the Church. What else is shaking your resolve now?”

“I… I am fine.”

“We have known each other for many years,” Valentine said, shaking his head. “Although by office you and I are equals, in daily life you have always treated me as an elder you can trust. I can see that something has been off with you ever since you came back. What exactly happened?”

Vanna was silent for a while. She looked up at the veiled Goddess, then after a moment lowered her gaze and looked at her own body.

Dante Wayne’s words still seemed to echo in her ears.

In the great fire eleven years ago, in that source of the flame the Enders had used to open the historical corruption, her uncle had actually failed to rescue her.

That fire was the beginning of the historical corruption, the dividing line between the true history and the false history. The people who died that night had truly died. Only after that fire did Pland’s destruction and its survival split into two completely opposite world lines.

In other words, she, a person who had died on the night of the fire, was never supposed to have survived.

It was Subspace’s divine blessing that had let her live until today.

The crazed shouts of that Ender atop the bell tower still rang in her ears:

“You will undergo true resurrection, and you will be born only to die again…”

She had already undergone true resurrection.

But she had not been born only to die again.

The appearance of the Vanished had cut all of that off.

Now she was still standing here in one piece, breathing the air of the mortal world and feeling the warmth of the living.

Even the storm Goddess still bestowed divine blessing on her, using the sea wind's gentle power to heal all the wounds on her body left by the earlier battles.

This even made Vanna feel, for the first time in her life, a confusion related to the Goddess.

Did the storm Goddess truly not care about the fact that she had survived only because of Subspace's divine blessing?

And as that doubt stretched and spread further, the things it led Vanna to think of made her shiver even more.

If what that Ender and Captain Duncan had said was true, then at this very moment the whole city-state of Pland had already been soaked in the Vanished's flames. Every person in this city-state, even the land itself, had already become blasphemous heretics.

Yet the divine blessing still remained in the great Cathedral. Every Deep Sea priest in Pland still received answers to their prayers to the Goddess just as before.

For the first time in her life, Vanna began to doubt the faith she had always held.

Chapter 218: The Survivors

The holy statue of the Storm Goddess Gamona stood quietly in the Cathedral, as it always did, majestic, mysterious, and silent.

The veil over her face seemed not only to cover the Goddess's features, but also to shroud some kind of link between the mortal world and the God. For the first time, Vanna realized that she did not actually know, and did not even understand, what kind of existence the God she worshipped really was.

All this time, she had taken it for granted to believe in everything about storms and the Deep Sea. She had never, until today, thought about these questions this way. She had never tried to look at her bond with the God from a questioning point of view.

She shivered and snapped out of her brief daze. Her heart pounded hard, and a layer of cold sweat broke out across her back.

Thoughts gave rise to heresy, and the gods must not be probed.

She could not believe that those almost blasphemous ideas had come out of her own head. To start questioning the God's "actions" was already little different from becoming a Heretic.

Yet in the next second, she heard the soft sound of waves by her ear. The familiar gaze and gentle comfort from the Goddess rose up as always, easing the pain built up in her body and soothing her mind.

Even here in the great Cathedral, even with such wavering thoughts in her heart, the Goddess was the same as ever… Was it because the gods were ignorant too, or because the Lord simply did not care?

"…You really don't need to rest?" Valentine's voice suddenly came from beside her, breaking off Vanna's second bout of distraction. The old man looked at the young Inquisitor at his side with worry. In his memory, Vanna had never stood this dazed before the Goddess. "You look absent-minded… Wounds of the body heal easily. Weariness of the mind is much more troublesome."

"I…" Vanna hesitated a little. "Maybe I really am a bit tired."

"Then go and rest. Leave the follow-up to me," Valentine said at once. Before she could say anything else, he quickly added: "I just got word that Mr. Dante has returned to the mansion safely. I think… your family needs you very much right now, and you need your family too."

"Uncle…" Vanna paused. The scene of parting with her uncle rose in her mind. A strange feeling tugged at her mood and finally pushed away her last bit of stubbornness. "All right, then I'll go first. I'll leave this place to you."

"Go without worry," Valentine nodded lightly. "May the storm shelter you."

"…May the storm shelter you." Vanna echoed softly.

A dark gray steam car drove out from the Cathedral square. After passing the checkpoint at the central district intersection, it headed first toward the Governor's mansion.

Vanna sat in the front passenger seat. At the wheel was Heidi, who had just finished answering questions inside the Cathedral.

"Thanks. I still have to trouble you to drive me," Vanna said quietly to her friend as the scenery slid backward outside the window. "You could have left much earlier."

“No need to be polite with me,” Heidi said casually as she watched the road and held the steering wheel. “And I couldn’t have left earlier anyway. That young friar asked me a whole pile of questions, then made me sit in incense smoke for half the day. All ‘necessary safety measures’. By the time they were done, it was already close to evening.”

Vanna looked out the window. She saw the city-state’s Guard Corps and Guardians patrolling the streets. Frightened citizens hurried across the road. Some people who looked like they had just left the shelters were stopping passersby to ask what had happened. Every so often she saw a Constable with a loudhailer standing at a corner, announcing the latest situation to the nearby crowd: that the city-state had been disturbed by Visions, that the danger had been removed, that a Third-Level Lockdown would be in effect tonight, and so on.

Pland looked like a patient just recovering from a serious illness. Order in the city-state was still chaotic. Yet even this tense and jumbled scene filled Vanna with an indescribable sense of relief and… warmth.

Fear and nerves were proof of being alive. Only those who had survived the disaster had the right to be this uneasy at this moment. And the sunrise of the next day would be the best comfort Pland could receive.

“You okay? You look awful,” Heidi asked. Even while driving, she noticed Vanna’s fatigue and dazed look. “This is the first time I’ve ever seen you like this since we were kids. I always thought you were forged from a sheet of steel.”

“…If I told you that when the Rain of Fire fell, I fought my way alone through the whole city-state, would you believe me?” Vanna glanced at her friend. After leaving with Heidi, her nerves had already begun to relax. “I’m exhausted.”

“I do, of course I do. It’s you we’re talking about. If you told me you fought your way back from Subspace, I’d believe it,” Heidi said without changing her expression, nodding as if it were obvious. Then she suddenly looked Vanna up and down. “No wonder you’re this drained…”

Vanna felt awkward under her gaze: “Your eyes look weird.”

“I just suddenly had an idea,” Heidi said with a serious face. “Do you want to go to the Marriage Counseling Center right now?”

“…Why?”

“It’s so rare to see you this weak. Maybe there’s finally someone you can’t beat up. That wouldn’t even break your second vow back then: ‘In every fight, I will give it my all’,” Heidi went on, her thoughts already flying, not caring at all about how Vanna’s expression was twisting. “Otherwise, after you go home and sleep, you’ll be invincible again, and the Marriage Counseling Center will have to keep sending people to the hospital every few days…”

Vanna curled her fist a little.

The sharp crack in the air made Heidi fall silent at once.

After two seconds of quiet, Heidi muttered: “If you don’t want to, you don’t want to. You’ve been threatening me since we were kids. You even stole my lunches…”

The car grew quiet. After a few seconds of silence, Vanna suddenly spoke softly: “Thanks. I feel much calmer now.”

“Of course. I am the best psychiatrist in Pland, after all. And you really do need to be in a good state to face Mr. Dante,” Heidi said with a satisfied smile, as if her plan had worked. Then she brought the car to a smooth stop. “You’re home, my invincible Lady Knight. Cheer up. Every one of us picked up an extra life today.”

Picked up an extra life…

Heidi had only said it casually, but for some reason, Vanna thought of something the believers of the death cult often said—

Survival was not a right given at birth, but a thing whose price had already been paid in advance.

Vanna lowered her eyes and took a slow breath. After thanking and saying goodbye to her friend, she got out of the car and walked toward the nearby front door.

Heidi sat in the car, quietly watching Vanna’s back as she walked away. After a while, she started the engine, turned the car around, and drove toward her own home.

Was Father safe now? If he was safe, then… what was he doing at this moment?

…

Outside the cabin, lightning flashed and thunder rolled as a storm rose. Gale winds drove huge waves that slammed again and again against the tall hull of the Vanished. Under the deep, dark sea surface, it felt as if some unnameable giant beast had been enraged and was pouring boundless malice into the world.

Through the porthole, they could see giants wreathed in blazing flame standing at the bow, their burning chains stretching down into the sea. Some vast creature with countless tentacles, almost as large as the Vanished itself, was thrashing wildly under the surface. Tentacles bristling with eyes and fanged mouths kept breaking out of the water and climbing up the hull, as if trying to tear free of the chains, or drive the Vanished out of this stretch of sea.

Inside the cabin, whale-oil lamps burned bright, yet they could not dispel the tension and fear. Shirley had already curled into a shivering ball with Dog in her arms, listening to the noise outside with a horrified face. Dog stretched his neck hard to keep from being choked and asked Alice: “Y-you… you’re sure the c-captain is just fishing?!”

“Of course,” Alice nodded calmly and firmly, with a look that seemed to say: “You city people are so easy to scare.” “Fishing is the captain’s biggest hobby.”

“I finally know why you always make that face whenever you talk about Mr. Duncan’s fish…” Shirley finally realized something. She looked at Dog with a miserable expression. “If… if I’d known back when I ate it…”

Before she could finish, Morris, who had been sitting across from them with his eyes closed, suddenly opened them. The old gentleman stared at the girl opposite him in horror: “You… ate the, uh, ‘fish’ Mr. Duncan caught?”

“How was I supposed to know?!” Shirley almost burst into tears. She turned her head toward Nina: “You… you never told me your uncle’s fish were caught like that…”

“I didn’t know either,” Nina shook her head. Her expression was not as exaggerated as the others. She even looked a little… excited. She leaned over the table, peering through the porthole at the scene on deck. The tentacles bursting out of the water did not frighten her. They only filled her with curiosity. “What do you think… how do those things end up turning into fish?”

To be fair, Nina was acting no different now than she did in the city-state, as cheerful and lively and bright as always. That kind of behavior was normal in peaceful streets. Staying like this at the Vanished’s “fishing spot” was

what made it a bit scary. Only now did Shirley seem to notice a startling side of Nina: “You and your uncle are both terrifying, really…”

Nina scratched her hair, looking puzzled: “Really? I think it’s fine…”

As they spoke, Alice suddenly stood up and walked out.

Shirley tensed up at once: “Ah, where are you going?”

“To get dinner ready, of course,” Alice said, as if it were obvious. “The captain is about to finish dealing with that big fish.”

Alice left, and the few people who had boarded the ship by accident, the Visitors, looked at one another in the cabin.

“I… I want to go home…” Shirley hugged Dog tight, on the verge of tears.

The red light in Dog’s bloodshot eyes flickered: “You’re choking me…”

Morris suddenly let out a sigh.

Nina quickly asked: “Teacher, why are you sighing?”

“I think I can write a book once I get back,” Morris said after thinking for a moment, spreading his hands. “I’m just worried my daughter will think I’ve lost my mind…”

Nina: “…?”

Chapter 219: The New Crew Members

Duncan returned to the cabin with a rich haul.

With a heavy thud, he threw down a big fish almost as tall as an adult. Then he tossed several smaller ugly fish beside it in a noisy scatter.

“Those fish really struggled today. Good thing I’m still stronger,” Duncan said in a proud, cheerful tone. He raised a hand to wipe his forehead. He had not actually broken a sweat, but as an angler showing off a pile of big fish, wiping his brow felt like the basic respect due to his catch. “Come and take a look. These count as a specialty from the depths of the Boundless Sea. They look ugly, but they taste pretty… Why do you all look like that?”

Duncan finally tore his gaze from his catch and looked up. In the cabin, Shirley, Morris, and Dog were all huddled far away. Dog’s expression was hard to read, but Morris and Shirley both clearly looked very unwell.

Only Nina ran over, greeting him as usual: “Uncle Duncan!”

Then she stared curiously at the fish on the floor.

They really were fish, though very ugly. They were indeed the same kind Uncle Duncan had brought home before.

“They’re really so ugly…” Nina sighed in wonder. “So they look even uglier before they get dried? And how did they end up like this…”

“Why do they all look like that?” Duncan finally asked, staring at Shirley and Morris on the other side of the cabin as if they had seen a ghost.

“They got scared by the noise when you were catching the fish, Uncle,” Nina answered at once. Then she thought for a moment and looked a bit embarrassed. “Actually, I was startled too. You make quite a scene when you fish…”

“I make a lot of noise when I fish?” Duncan frowned in confusion, as if he faintly sensed something. He looked up at Morris sitting far away. “Did something happen just now?”

Only then did Morris carefully get up from his chair. He cautiously approached the ugly strange fish, bent down, and looked them over again and again. Only after he confirmed they had really turned into fish did he speak, hesitating: “Mr. Duncan, are you… on very bad terms with the Deep Sea Spawn? Bad enough that you twisted them into this shape…”

Duncan froze. He finally understood what the constant sense of wrongness had been. He slowly turned his head toward Nina and said thoughtfully: “… In your eyes, what I caught weren’t fish?”

“They are now, but they weren’t before,” Nina answered in a small voice, sticking out her tongue. “We saw you fighting something huge just now. It looked… like this…”

Nina stretched her arms wide, trying to show the size of that vast sea monster that should never appear within human reason. Then she described what she had seen on deck just now. As she spoke, Duncan’s expression grew serious, and he sank into thought.

“That’s about it,” Nina finally finished. She glanced again at the bizarre fish, sounding full of disbelief. “We just didn’t expect that thing to actually turn into… fish.”

Duncan fell silent for a while before muttering thoughtfully: “That sounds like a very large octopus…”

Shirley, who had been hiding and saying nothing, finally plucked up her courage and edged closer. She could not help asking when she heard that: “Octopus? What’s that?”

“It’s also edible,” Duncan explained. “It looks scary, but it tastes fine.”

At those words, Shirley and Morris’s faces both twisted into quite a sight again.

Duncan paid no attention to their reactions. He only stared at his catch and fell into thought.

So the “fish” he caught had not been fish at the start.

The Deep Sea Spawn, the terrible monsters of the Boundless Sea, the sea monsters that made captains and sailors tremble, only became fish after he “hooked” them.

Why did this change happen?

At first Duncan felt surprise and confusion, but in the end, all of it merged into a more basic question:

Could he still eat the fish?

Duncan hesitated for a moment, but after a few seconds he had his answer. He had eaten them before, and aside from looking ugly, they tasted quite good.

This was the Boundless Sea. The Boundless Sea already held endless strange things. Compared with those truly unspeakable Great Terrors, what was so shocking about Deep Sea monsters turning into ugly fish once they came ashore? The words “Deep Sea Spawn” sounded impressive, but if you loosened your thinking a bit, Deep Sea Spawn were just another sort of sea

monster. Looking over human civilization, how many creatures once treated as terrifying beasts had eventually ended up on the table?

In Duncan's view, the essence of the whole thing was just one kind of ingredient turning into another kind of ingredient on the Vanished…

"I've eaten it anyway." These words wiped away all his doubts. He decided not to worry about it. He could just treat it as having uncovered the secret behind this ingredient's delicious taste. If he was really worried, he could always ask Alice to cook it a bit longer.

Shirley and Morris watched as Duncan's expression turned cheerful again and heard his conclusion: "No need to think too hard. I'll take these fish to the kitchen first."

Shirley forgot to be cautious: "We're really going to eat them?!"

"It's not like you haven't before," Duncan said, giving the young lady a strange look. "Didn't you enjoy them last time?"

Shirley: "…"

No matter what the Visitors thought, this special dinner on the Vanished was served in the end.

And for Duncan, today was bound to be a special day too.

After such a long stretch of emptiness, the Vanished finally had a day that could barely be called "lively". In the cabin amidships, the dining room that had been shut for so long was opened again. Bright whale-oil lamps drove away the gloom. The long table had been polished until it shone, and on it lay the richest meal the ship could offer now—

Freshly baked bread, vegetable soup, stewed peas and meat, jam and mashed potatoes, two kinds of light wine and one strong liquor, and fish.

And of course, AI's fries and ketchup.

Duncan sat at one end of the long table, with Nina beside him and Alice on his other side to make up the numbers. Along the sides sat Shirley, Dog, Morris, and AI.

To be fair, compared with the huge dining room and long table, this small handful of people did not really count as “lively”. Strictly speaking, Morris was the only truly ordinary person here. Even so, this would be the most atmospheric meal Duncan had had since coming aboard this ship.

After all, normally the only ones at his side when he ate were Goathead or Alice. The whole ship could not even produce two people who ate human food. When AI finally appeared, her menu had only fries…

And for the few Visitors who had come aboard today, this would likely be the most unbelievable, most unforgettable meal of their lives.

Morris looked down at his plate. The roast fish that Alice had cut with her own hands sat at the center. After cooking, the Spawn’s flesh no longer showed any eerie or frightening trace. It looked like real food, even giving off an inviting smell.

Sitting on the Vanished, living alongside the Shadows of Subspace, sharing the flesh of the Deep Sea Spawn.

Morris almost could not help whispering the holy name of the God of Wisdom Rahm, but he was afraid the God might actually send him a divine blessing and let him see something he should never see.

The atmosphere around the table felt a bit stiff. Duncan noticed this, so he was the first to raise his glass: “First of all, let me welcome you all again. The process was a bit unexpected, but you are now all members of the Vanished. Let’s use this drink as a welcoming ritual.”

Their inner tension quickly gave way. Morris hurriedly lifted his glass and stood. Shirley followed, and Nina copied her. But Duncan quickly glanced

at the two girls: “Juice is enough for you two.”

“I’m almost an adult!” Shirley blurted out on reflex.

“I… I’ll just sip a little,” Nina said in a small voice. “Fruit wine would be fine…”

“…Then you two may only drink a little,” Duncan said seriously. “I’ll have Alice keep an eye on you.”

“Okay, Uncle! Okay, Mr. Duncan!”

Morris watched the exchange between Shirley, Nina, and Duncan with some surprise. The scene felt almost too down-to-earth, and it suddenly loosened his taut nerves a little.

And not just Morris’s nerves.

When Nina eagerly took a sip of fruit wine and still ended up coughing again and again, the whole dining room seemed to relax.

Duncan felt it was time to talk about his next ideas and plans.

“After dinner, I’ll have AI take you back to the city-state,” he said, looking around the table, his tone relaxed and calm. “Mr. Morris, you can go straight home. Shirley, Dog, and Nina, you can return to the antique shop.”

Nina was still recovering from her coughing fit when she heard his words and suddenly thought of something: “Cough, cough… Uncle… then you…”

“Of course I’ll be waiting for you there,” Duncan said with a smile, his gaze also resting on Shirley. “In fact, that’s always been the case. I am both here and in the city-state.”

“Uh…” Shirley stared for a few seconds before blinking. “I thought… after you solved Pland’s problem, you wouldn’t pay attention to that city

anymore. That you would, like in the stories, just keep sailing on with your adventure…”

“Of course the captain will keep adventuring. The Vanished will still sail on the Boundless Sea,” Duncan said, half smiling as he looked at her. “But the captain still watches the civilized world. As for the Vanished’s crew members… you will go back to the land you know, but there is always the chance you’ll come aboard again if the situation calls for it.”

“…We have to come back?!” Shirley froze for a moment before reacting.

Nina reacted too: “We can come back?!”

Chapter 220: Group

Anyone who encountered the Vanished would inevitably form a “connection” with Duncan. From another angle, Duncan, this “outsider”, also needed to build such connections widely in this world. Only by gaining as many channels of knowledge and help as possible could he learn more about this world, learn about the supernatural field, and even… learn about himself.

The reason Morris and the others were brought onto the ship might have been just the urgency of the situation at the time. But even if they had not boarded today, Duncan already planned to expand his “influence” in this world. In his eyes, the few people now gathered on the Vanished just happened to be excellent candidates.

Morris, an outstanding historian, a learned scholar, and a believer of the God of Wisdom, held precious knowledge. That was what Duncan lacked most right now. At the same time, this old gentleman was also a “social elite” with a certain status and network in the human world. At the right time, that would also be very useful.

Shirley and Dog, a controlled Abyssal demon and the summoner who had a symbiotic pact with that demon, had fighting power. They also held knowledge about the Abyssal Deep and even some knowledge related to Subspace. This knowledge happened to complement Morris, the “human scholar”. Besides that, the pair had a special way of sensing. They could detect traces left by supernatural power at no cost or at a very small cost.

Nina, his well-behaved and adorable niece.

And, incidentally, the current vessel of the Sun fragment.

Duncan’s gaze slowly swept across the long table. Around it, some faces were tense, some stiff, and some simply filled with curiosity.

They did not seem to notice that a very special “group” had already faintly taken shape during this dinner. What tied this group together was the shared identity they all had at this moment:

crew members of the Vanished.

“My earlier promise still stands. Your status as crew members of the Vanished will not restrict your personal freedom. I do not need forced loyalty, and I do not need any sacrificial rites or offerings and the like. None of that has any meaning to me,” Duncan said slowly. His voice was low, and the gentle sound of waves drifted in through the porthole not far away. “But since the link between you and me has already been established, this link can be seen as the foundation for a loose team.”

“To be honest, I had stayed away from the civilized world for many years. Morris should know this very well. The Vanished had not had contact with any city-state in the past century. In the civilized world there are many terrifying stories about me and about this ship. I admit those stories have a basis in fact, because for many years… this ship was in a runaway state.

“But as you can see, I took back my humanity and stabilized the Vanished again. And now… I am very interested in the civilized world a century later.”

Duncan spoke unhurriedly. These were words he had carefully prepared earlier while fishing. He needed to recruit crew members, but the terrifying history of the Vanished meant that any new recruit coming aboard would not be in a good mood about their new post. So he needed a set of reasonable, gentle, and proper reasons to calm the emotions of these new

recruits. The first step was to build an image of a rational and friendly captain.

The Vanished had once been in a runaway state, but now the captain had reclaimed his humanity and regained control of the ship. That was the premise for the team to exist.

As for whether the new recruits believed it or not… that was their problem.

He had to admit, fishing really was a relaxing pastime that was good for thinking. Duncan felt he really should thank nature for its gift… or thank the Deep Sea Spawn instead.

Hearing Duncan's explanation, a thoughtful look appeared on Morris's face. He still did not quite dare to believe that the voice he heard was truly real. In fact, he did not even dare to believe that the Vanished he saw now was truly the real ship. But when he recalled the friendly attitude Duncan had always shown, he slowly began to persuade himself.

At the very least, if this explanation was true, the friendly behavior of this Subspace shadow would seem a bit more reasonable and believable.

Shirley was still thinking, as if she had not fully understood what was going on. But Dog, sitting beside her, had already reacted. The Abyssal Hound took a bold glance at Duncan and asked: "So that means you need us to be your retainers, to help you do some things in the world?"

"Only when it is needed," Duncan said with a smile. "When I need it. Besides, I do not think this relationship counts as retainers. You are crew members, so just call me Captain. Or you can keep addressing me the way you did before."

Shirley and Dog both answered with a simple "Oh". Not far away, after a brief pause to think, Morris suddenly spoke: "Then how will you contact

us? Ah, of course, I know you have an avatar in the city-state of Pland, but I mean…”

“I know what you mean,” Duncan said, nodding lightly before Morris could finish. “If I want to find you, I will naturally find you at once. And if something happens and you need to contact me, you can call my name or the name of the Vanished near a smooth mirror surface. I can hear it. Besides, fire can strengthen my power, so if you are in danger, you can light a flame after calling my name.”

Morris listened, his expression a little complicated. After all, he was still a believer of the God of Wisdom, yet now he had half willingly joined a heretical group like this and was even learning knowledge from a Subspace shadow. That made him feel somewhat uneasy. But what made him even more uneasy was that the charm bracelet on his wrist, with its remaining four stone beads, did not react at all.

The Lord did not see. The Lord did not care. The Lord thought he was right. No matter which answer it was, it made the old gentleman feel complicated inside.

After hearing Duncan’s words, Nina’s eyes widened a little. She even looked a bit excited: “That sounds amazing!”

Duncan gave her a light look and said: “You do not need any extra fire…”

Nina did not react for a moment. “Huh? Why?”

Then, before Duncan could answer, she suddenly understood. She waved her hands in a hurry and said: “Oh, I get it, I get it, I can…”

“Do not change here!” Duncan saw the air around Nina already starting to twist a little and quickly cut her off. “Before you can fully control the power brought by the Sun fragment, you are not allowed to try to switch your form in enclosed spaces or in crowded places!”

Nina’s head drooped at once. “Oh…”

Duncan watched the air around the young lady slowly return to normal and felt the heat fade away. Only then did he let out a soft breath of relief.

With the help of this Flame Usurper bearer, the Sun fragment inside Nina was already under control. But clearly, the young lady herself still did not fully realize how powerful the force sleeping inside her really was. No matter how mature and sensible she might be, she was still only sixteen or seventeen. For someone that age, the fresh rush brought by first touching supernatural power was not so easy to suppress.

If there was a chance, he still needed to let her get used to her power more out here on the wide, empty Boundless Sea. On one hand, that would make the Sun fragment more controllable. On the other, it would make her understand just how dangerous that star-born flame really was.

“We might add new members in the future,” Duncan thought for a moment, then said. “So let us treat a dinner like today as the standard process for a new recruit joining. I think it will help deepen the bonds between team members.”

Morris subconsciously glanced at the plate before him and felt that he was seeing the truth hidden behind a warm, cozy scene once again.

Dining together under the gaze of a Subspace shadow, sharing the flesh and blood of a Deep Sea Spawn, and learning rituals and spells to summon supernatural power, this…

The whole set really gave him a strong sense of deja vu.

But what else could he say? He was already a member of this ship. He had already accepted Mr. Duncan’s protection. The flesh of the Deep Sea Spawn, the key part of this ritual, already sat before him. At this point, quitting was impossible. He could only, like the pigeon beside him that had

been gobbling fries since just now, calmly accept the fate of “it really is delicious”…

The old gentleman let out a soft sigh in his heart and fully accepted this sudden turn in his fate, while silently comforting himself. From today on, he was like those legendary scholars whose names were worthy of the history books, stepping onto a one way road toward the abyss of truth. There was probably nothing left in this world that could still strike him as strange or sinister.

As he was thinking this, he suddenly heard Miss Alice, who had been silent not far away, break the silence. The beautiful lady had been standing quietly behind Duncan the whole time, and only now did she seem to realize something: “Ah, Captain, does that mean I will not be the only crew member here anymore?”

“You only just realized?” Duncan tilted his head and glanced at the doll. “Of course you are no longer the only crew member here. And before they leave later, you still have to teach them the crew rules, just like Goathead taught you back then.”

Alice froze for a moment, finally understanding what was going on. Then she belatedly smiled and clapped her hands happily. “Great! Then from now on I will…”

The next second, maybe because she was too excited, a familiar sound reached Duncan’s ear. “Pop!”

A head still wearing a golden wig dropped down right beside him and rolled to the middle of the table in full view of everyone.

The table went silent at once, until Shirley’s scream broke it. “Aaah, the head fell off, the head fell off! It fell, it fell, it fell!”

The scene instantly became chaotic. Shirley and Nina shouted in shock, Dog was cursing, and Alice’s stammering cries for help rose again and again. Mixed in with it was AI’s loud cooing. Morris watched all of this with a blank expression and suddenly felt that it might take him much longer to fully get used to this new team…

Chapter 221: Reunion

The familiar house stood quietly at the end of the quiet street, bright and warm light shining out from the windows on the first floor.

The sky was already completely dark. The streetlights on both sides of the road made the surroundings seem even more still. Heidi slowed the car a little. In the last hundred meters before the house gate, she used slow, deep breaths to gently adjust her feelings.

She had helped Vanna calm down, but she knew that her own mood was not as relaxed and calm as she seemed.

The scene of saying goodbye to Father felt as if it had happened only a moment ago. At that time she still had no idea what would happen in the city state, while Father had clearly sensed something already.

It was a farewell between life and death that she only understood afterward.

Father had told her to go to the Cathedral to seek shelter, while he himself went to that antique shop in the Lower City. But why did he have to go to that antique shop?

A trace of doubt rose in Heidi’s heart, but she quickly set it aside. The light in the entry hall at home was on. It was waiting for her.

The dark gray car drove smoothly into the yard. Heidi pushed open the front door, walked a few steps inside, and suddenly stopped in surprise.

The one waiting for her at home was not Father, who in theory should have gotten back long ago, but Mother. Mother wore a wool shawl with dark blue

stripes and sat on a high backed chair by the dining table, a delicate pair of glasses on her nose as she read the newspaper with full attention. On the table beside her sat a tall stack of newspapers, which looked like old issues that had been moved out of Father's study.

Heidi froze in the doorway of the dining room, unable to react for a moment.

She could no longer remember how long it had been since Mother last walked out of that bedroom. It seemed that for many years, the Mother in her memory had always stayed in that dimly lit room, while there was always an empty seat left by the dining table at home. Father said that seat was reserved for Mother, yet no one ever sat there.

Heidi had always felt this was very strange, but after so many years, she had grown used to Mother never leaving the room. Until now. Seeing Mother sitting in that chair, she felt an unreal sensation, as if a whole lifetime had passed.

Heidi walked forward two steps without thinking. Her footsteps finally drew the old lady's attention. Mother looked up, saw her daughter, and at once smiled. "Ah, Heidi, you are back."

"I…" Heidi opened her mouth and suddenly did not know how to talk to her Mother. She clearly went to her parents' bedroom almost every day to greet her, yet at this moment she felt as if she had not seen Mother in more than ten years. "I was delayed for a while at the Cathedral. Are you… are you feeling better?"

"I am fine. I am right here," Mother said happily with a smile. There was a light in her eyes that Heidi could not read. She rose from the chair and slowly came to stand in front of her daughter. She stared a little dazed at Heidi's face, then reached out and touched her hair. "Let me look at you properly… It has been so long since I really looked at you…"

“Do we not see each other every day?” Heidi said without thinking. Then she looked at the old lady with some worry. “Why did you come out of the bedroom? Are you feeling better today?”

Mother smiled, as if talking to herself, yet also as if speaking to her daughter. “I am better, I am better… By the way, why is Morris still not back?”

“Father has not come home yet?” Heidi froze when she heard this, a faint worry rising in her heart. “He should have been here earlier. The place he went is closer than the Cathedral, and he would not have been delayed for half a day like me…”

“Maybe the car broke down on the way,” Mother said slowly. “His driving skills have never been anything to praise. Come, let us wait for him together.”

Heidi hesitated, then nodded and followed Mother back to the table. Soon she noticed the rich dishes laid out there. They were not the few simple dishes usually made by the temporary maid the family had hired.

“Did you cook this?” Heidi looked up in surprise. “It has been so long since you cooked.”

“Yes, it has been a long time. I could not even find where the ingredients were. I had to ask that maid to help me find many of them, and I do not know how it tastes,” Mother said with a faint smile. “Luckily, I still remember the general steps.”

Heidi listened, her gaze dropping to the food on the table. She could not help picking up her fork, wanting to taste a bite. But just as she raised her hand, Mother’s voice came from the side. “Wait until your Father gets home before we eat.”

Heidi’s movement stopped at once.

She had not heard that sentence in many years either.

Just then, a faint sound suddenly came from near the door. It sounded like the flapping of some large bird’s wings, mixed with soft crackling. Heidi had just begun to wonder what it was when she heard the sound of someone taking out a key and turning the knob. The front door opened not far away.

Father was back.

Morris stood blankly in the doorway. The dizziness caused by AI teleporting him straight from the Vanished had not yet faded. The rolling, chaotic sensations made his head spin so much that for more than ten seconds, he thought he was hallucinating.

He saw his wife sitting by the dining table, waiting for him to come home and eat.

Then he realized it was not an illusion.

The sacred miracle he had prayed for from Subspace eleven years ago had finally, after this crossing of flame and history, become fixed on this side of the Veil. Something he had not dared to hope for even in his dreams had come true.

After standing like a statue for a long moment, Morris finally moved. He took a step forward, then walked faster and faster.

On the Vanished, he had shared the flesh of the Deep Sea Spawn with the retainers, learned Listening rite knowledge from a Subspace shadow, and become a member of a secret society. Just a short while ago, these things had weighed on his heart like a heavy burden. But suddenly, that weight seemed to vanish. In all of this, he seemed to glimpse the most reasonable explanation.

The fulfillment of any sacred miracle required a price to be paid. Now that price had fallen on him in the gentlest, warmest way.

It was time to accept it gladly.

His wife rose from the table, and Morris pulled her into a tight embrace.

“I can finally see you…” The old scholar’s voice was low, as if he feared that Heidi might overhear yet also feared that his wife would not. “I…”

“All right, the child is watching. You will have plenty of time to explain to me what happened. There is no rush right now.”

“Oh… oh, you are right, you are right.”

Morris answered in a bit of a panic. He let go of his wife and turned his head, and saw Heidi looking at them in surprise.

“Ahem… I came back late. On the way… the car broke down. I will have to find someone to tow it back tomorrow,” Morris explained awkwardly, then quickly changed the subject. “Are you all right? At the Cathedral… everything was fine?”

“Except for being badly frightened and full of confusion, I am unharmed, just like everyone else,” Heidi answered, then looked her father up and down. “But you… why do I feel you are acting strange? Did something happen on the way back?”

“What could happen to me?” Morris said at once, as if afraid Heidi would steer the topic toward what he had been doing lately. Right after that, he noticed the rich dishes on the table.

The old scholar’s expression instantly became complicated.

“I… already ate before coming back,” he said hesitantly. “On the ship… at Mr. Duncan’s place.”

The ugly, terrifying “fish” appeared in his mind.

At the Feast of Subspace, he had been as nervous about the fish as that strange Abyssal Hound. But under Mr. Duncan's gaze, he had still forced himself to eat the flesh of the Deep Sea Spawn. He did not remember very clearly what had happened afterward.

He only remembered that it had been truly delicious.

Right now, he felt he could not eat another bite.

But his wife's voice came from the side just then. "I made this myself."

"Mother has not cooked in many years," Heidi quickly added. "She felt a bit better today, so…"

"Then I will have some more." As soon as Morris heard that, he sat down at the table before his daughter could finish her sentence. The first thing he did was pick up the soup bowl and pour down a big gulp.

"How does it… taste?" his wife asked expectantly from the side.

"A little… salty," Morris said hesitantly. Then he raised the bowl again and gulped down several more mouthfuls, swallowing as he laughed. "Salty, very salty… Your cooking is always this salty…"

"If you think it is bad, then do not eat it!"

"I never said it was bad…"

"Then shut your mouth and eat. Why are you talking so much at the table?"

Heidi looked up and glanced at her father, then at her mother.

She had not heard this kind of conversation in many years. After all these years, it seemed that nothing had changed.

So she smiled, lowered her head, cut off a piece of fried steak, and put it into her mouth.

It really was a little salty.

…

Uncle had already gone to bed and was sleeping very soundly. It seemed he had not had a good sleep in a very, very long time, so much so that he had started nodding off halfway through their conversation.

Vanna slowly walked toward her bedroom.

She had already changed into a simple home dress and tied her hair into a ponytail. After taking off her scarred armor and putting down the greatsword, the battle worn Inquisitor drew back all her killing intent. She now looked like a young lady who, like any ordinary person, had her own life and her own joys and sorrows.

At home, she did not hide her feelings or her worries, so Uncle had clearly seen how heavy her heart was. But during their talk just now, he had not asked anything.

The two of them had also, with silent agreement, avoided mentioning the Subspace divine blessing.

It was clear that Uncle did not want to add to her burden.

But Vanna knew very well that the burden in her heart just now was not only that so called Subspace divine blessing. It was not even about her own life and death.

She returned to her bedroom, closed the door, went to the dressing table, and took from the drawer the ritual dagger with the ornate patterns.

This was a sacred relic of the Deep Sea Church. It was also the gift that Valentine, the bishop, had personally blessed and given to her after she received baptism.

This sacred relic marked the beginning of her faith in Gamona, the storm goddess.

Chapter 222: Wavering

As always, Vanna calmed herself and silently recited the sacred passages from Storm Canon. Then she took from the drawer a half-burned Inscribed Candle, set it by her side, and lit it on the candlestick.

A small, bright flame danced at the tip of the candle. A soothing scent spread slowly as the oil evaporated. Vanna drew in a gentle breath, then, without hesitation, dragged the dagger across her arm.

Blood seeped into the fine patterns on the dagger, as if the blade absorbed it. A brief pain came from her arm, but it did not even last a few seconds before it turned into the faint itch of a closing wound.

Vanna could even hear the soft sound of cells regenerating and blood congealing. She watched as the wound on her arm healed quickly, while the faint sound of waves seemed to echo by her ears.

She looked again at the ritual dagger in her hand. After a slight pause, she held the bloodstained blade over the burning candle and let the flame lick the tip.

“Please hear this Listening Rite, Master of the Storm, Gospel of The Deep Sea, Maiden of the Still Sea. Please hear this Listening Rite. Your follower needs guidance…”

The flame crackled. The blood on the dagger ignited in an instant and turned into a hazy glow that floated along the blade.

This was the sign that the channel had been opened.

A Saint could, using blood as a guide, a special Prayer, and a special ritual, build between herself and the God a channel far more stable and direct than what an ordinary priest achieved in Prayer. This special power and “favor” was exactly what set a Saint apart from the rest of the Clergy.

And as for how stable and how direct this special “channel” truly was…

In a sense, it was almost the same as speaking directly with a god.

The soft sound of waves rose again, growing clearer as if it echoed right inside her mind. Vanna felt the air around her grow damp. Even her nose seemed to catch a faint salty tang. Then her thoughts suddenly blurred, and the scene before her changed.

Her familiar bedroom vanished. Around her stretched endless, gently surging dark-blue seawater. Faint blue lights rose and fell in the depths, as if hundreds of mysterious light sources glowed within The Deep Sea. Vanna felt as if she stood at the center of some vast, shadowy Deep Sea domain. In the rippling light before her, a blurred figure slowly emerged.

It seemed to be a Lady in a long dress. Behind her, vast hazy Shadows spread in all directions. The Lady’s face was hidden behind a veil. The Shadows behind her coiled and wove together like countless chains, or like the outline of some much larger “body” that lay beyond Mortal reason. The figure in the dress was only a small part of that immense body—the one small part Mortals could still bear to perceive.

Vanna drew in a slow breath and tried to steady her heartbeat.

As a Saint, seeing the storm Goddess Gamona’s phantom or avatar form during a special ritual was nothing unusual. But when she thought of how shaken she had been today, and of the almost heretical doubts in her heart, she still could not help feeling nervous.

The mysterious blurred figure seemed to draw a little closer. “She” did not speak, but Vanna felt a “thought” appear directly in her mind.

The Goddess’s phantom was telling her to speak.

“I…” Vanna hesitated for a moment. At last she seemed to make up her mind and spoke directly: “I survived because of Subspace. Why did you still choose me as a Saint and grant me your divine blessing?”

The blurred figure did not move at all. Vanna did not dare to push. She knew that, even though she saw only a projection, that projection pointed straight to Gamona herself. The question she had just asked was a huge risk —

It already went beyond what was proper for a Believer. But she truly wanted to know the answer.

She waited in anxious silence. She did not know how long had passed before a thought suddenly dropped into her mind as if planted there—

“…There is no difference…”

“No difference?” Vanna froze. This answer, cut off at both ends, was even harder to understand than a broken, obscure prophecy or revelation. She instinctively felt that this reply should have other “context” around it, information she had failed to grasp and so could not hear. That thought made her ask again before she could stop herself: “No difference in what? I don’t understand. Do you mean that, even knowing I was once blessed by Subspace, you still chose…”

But Vanna did not finish. The Deep Sea vision around her suddenly lurched and roiled. The gentle, bright lights in the depths went dark one after another. The Goddess’s phantom was on the verge of collapse in the blink of an eye. Vanna felt herself being “pushed” out of the channel. Before the connection was completely cut, she barely sensed a few faint words:

“…Time is short… about to… reach the threshold…”

The connection broke completely.

Vanna felt as if she had been thrown back into the Mortal Realm. Her heart pounded. A near-suffocating pressure made her gasp for breath. She lifted her head and looked around. All the visions had vanished. The dagger had fallen onto the table at some point. Only the Inscribed Candle still burned quietly, its flame flickering, unsteady.

She did not know how long she stared at the flame before she finally looked away. She picked up the fallen dagger and slowly put it back into the drawer.

In her mind circled the only fragments she had received during that brief exchange.

“There is no difference,” and, “Time is short, about to reach the threshold.”

She still had no idea what the first meant. The second sounded more concrete, but it only left her more confused.

Was the Goddess telling her that something was about to happen? Was this a warning that the time to prepare for something was running out? What did “threshold” mean? What was about to reach it? Another crisis? Another disaster on the level of a Mortal Realm invasion?

Was it connected to the crisis Pland had just survived?

Vanna’s thoughts spun. This Prayer had not calmed her at all. Instead, she felt even more uneasy than during the day.

But suddenly, a strange color flickered at the edge of her vision, and her chaotic thoughts stopped at once.

The flame dancing on the Inscribed Candle had, at some point, taken on a faint ghostly green.

In the next second, she snapped her head up toward the dressing table and the oval mirror upon it.

Captain Duncan's figure had appeared within the frame, watching her with a calm gaze.

"Are you all right?"

The dark, imposing figure spoke. The question came very abruptly.

"You?" Vanna jolted and shot to her feet. Then, as if something occurred to her, she added: "Were you the one who disrupted my ritual just now?"

"ritual? I think you misunderstood," Duncan said in the mirror, shaking his head with an easy tone. "I suddenly sensed your aura in extreme turmoil. I thought there was still some troublesome enemy left in Pland, so I came to check… but it seems I was rash."

Sense her aura in chaos… so he came to check on her?

Vanna's mind filled with question marks. She even wondered if she had misheard. Then she recalled the first time she had seen him in the mirror and, by reflex, grew wary again: "Did you drag me into a dream again?"

"You're still in the Mortal Realm, you don't need to worry about that," Duncan said casually. "So I strongly advise you not to leap in here swinging like last time—you really will turn your own room into a mess."

"…I am not some brute who only knows how to jump in swinging," Vanna muttered. Talking with this ghost captain was exhausting. His words and actions always went beyond the records, and every time she was caught off guard like this, she found herself relaxing her guard without meaning to. "Besides 'coming to check on things', what else do you intend to do? I thought… you had already left for good."

In the mirror, Duncan frowned, as if the young Inquisitor's tense hostility gave him a headache. "You really could relax a little. And maybe be a bit more polite. I have indeed left, but distance in time and space doesn't mean much to me. Also—no matter how you look at it, I just protected your city-state. Don't you think you at least owe me a word of thanks?"

Vanna stared hard at the ghost captain in the mirror. After a few seconds, she suddenly stepped forward and actually bowed her head. "Thank you very much for your help. At least in this matter, Pland was under your protection."

This frank gratitude caught Duncan off guard. He had thought this young lady's head was as hard as her muscles. The surprise actually made him a bit embarrassed. "It… doesn't have to be that serious. I was just saying."

"Our positions may be different, but no one can deny that you protected Pland," Vanna said, lifting her head with a serious face. "Countless people survived the disaster today. Setting aside my duty as an Inquisitor, I should thank you for that."

She paused there, then quickly straightened her expression. "But that does not mean I will relax my vigilance toward you and the Vanished. We still do not know what your goal is regarding the civilized world… and until that is clear, I will…"

"That's enough, I understand," Duncan cut her off. He looked at the young Inquisitor with a half-smile. Her words and attitude were far from polite, but this almost overly straightforward nature made it hard to dislike her. "Then let's talk about something else… You seem to be in trouble?"

Vanna met Duncan's gaze. After a few seconds, she drew a quiet breath. "Sorry. It has nothing to do with you."

“…Nothing to do with me, but I’m curious,” Duncan said calmly. “Whether you admit it or not, you cannot shake off the brand I left on you, Vanna. I can feel how bad your state is right now—maybe I can help.”

Chapter 223: Deepening Understanding

To be fair, Duncan was truly sincere at this moment. He admired this Inquisitor’s firm will and blunt nature. He admired how she had acted in the disaster. Even aside from that, he valued Vanna as a special Node very highly.

If not for a string of coincidences, it would have been very hard to plant such a Node among the Church’s top people. Building even the most basic “connection” with such a person was harder still.

Vanna was very straightforward. Because of that, she would not deny Duncan’s merit in protecting Pland. No matter how awkward she felt, she would treat this favor from a Lord fairly.

But Duncan’s sincere attitude would sound more or less terrifying to anyone else.

A bond that could not be cut, like The curse. Subspace Shadows that could invade her thoughts at any time. A higher being so powerful it could reverse a corruption in history, yet with unknown aims—if not for Vanna’s iron will, anyone else would have failed their sanity check several times over by now.

Vanna steadied herself and met Duncan’s gaze without flinching, though her heart stayed tense. Rationally, she still did not dare to believe every word this ghost captain said. Even if he truly had protected Pland, there might be

some more terrible scheme behind it—history was full of such schemes. But emotionally…

Her feelings kept telling her not to trust reason too much.

"…What do you really want?" Vanna drew a slow breath. She was questioning him again, but this time there was more than defiance and wariness in her tone. There was seriousness. She wanted to talk properly with this legendary captain and listen carefully to what he had to say. Even if they could not be Friends, they did not have to be enemies for the moment.

After she said this, she paused, then added quickly: "And don't say something like 'get some fries' again… I want to hear something serious."

"…'Get some fries' was serious," Duncan said helplessly. "With lots of ketchup, if possible."

Vanna: "…?"

"I'm trying to improve the food on my ship. Isn't that obvious?" Duncan suddenly laughed. None of Vanna's reactions surprised him. He moved a little in the mirror, as if sitting down on something, and continued in a very relaxed posture: "Vanna, what do you think a captain like me does most of the time?"

"What you do most of the time?" Vanna blinked. She did not notice that their tense conversation had already turned… calmer. Once the figure in the mirror sat down, the talk that followed felt almost like two Friends chatting. "I… never really thought about that…"

"Exactly. You haven't. No one ever thinks about that. A terrifying ghost captain only has to be 'terrifying'. I'm supposed to spend twenty-four hours a day plotting world-shaking schemes. That would fit the story people tell about me. But in reality?"

Duncan spread his hands as he spoke.

“I have a very, very large ship to manage, and a lot of troublesome people on that ship. My Crew Members are always causing a commotion, turning the deck upside down every now and then. The food on the Vanished is another headache. But the biggest problem is hot water. I’m thinking about installing a boiler on board. Do you have any recommendations?”

“I don’t know much about boilers… Wait, no, that’s not the point,” Vanna answered without thinking. Halfway through, she realized something was wrong. She stared wide-eyed at the ghost captain in the mirror, whose half-smile seemed full of teasing… and amusement at her. “Why are you suddenly telling me all this? And… um… are you serious?”

Duncan shifted his posture. He looked into Vanna’s eyes, and his expression slowly grew serious. “Vanna, have you noticed? I’m not as frightening as you imagine. The unknown is the source of fear. Now you know a little more about me.”

Vanna did not speak for a moment. She could no longer keep up with this captain’s pacing and had no idea how to respond.

But after a short silence, she let out a slow breath and tried to change the subject. “…You took away the fragment of the Sun. That also removed another great danger in Pland. I should thank you for that as well.”

The corner of Duncan’s mouth twitched almost invisibly. “…It was nothing. I have a hobby of collecting things.”

But in truth, he wanted to say that he had already sent the fragment of the Sun back to Pland. Nina had first been excited to spend the night on the ship, but then she found she could not sleep anywhere but her own bed…

Duncan was afraid that if he said that out loud, Vanna would leap in swinging again on the spot…

Vanna did not notice the tiny change in his expression. She only nodded lightly and went on: “Order in the city-state is gradually returning. The lingering corruption caused by the Ender has fully faded. And those cultists who tried to summon the Black Sun… have become, just as they wished, fuel for the flames. I hope you are satisfied with that outcome.”

“It’s fine. They’ll show up again sooner or later anyway,” Duncan said offhandedly. “Heretic worshipers are the breath of an Eldritch God. As long as those ‘sources’ are not destroyed, you can never wipe out the cultists completely—just keep cleaning them up the next time you see them.”

Vanna listened thoughtfully to every word, her expression only slightly curious. “It sounds like… you have a very bad relationship with those heretic worshipers.”

“You’re trying to gather intelligence,” Duncan said with a smile. “This is a rare chance in a hundred years to learn directly about ‘Captain Duncan’ and the Vanished—but you can just ask.”

Vanna was speechless for a moment, her face a little awkward. But soon she heard the ghost captain’s frank answer from the mirror: “I don’t like those cultists. I don’t like the Suntists or the Ender. As for the Annihilators who worship the Abyssal Lord… I don’t know them well, but most of them are probably the sort of madmen who annoy me.

“So you can report that straight up the chain. Say that the Vanished is an enemy of all three major cults, and that, whenever conditions allow, Captain Duncan will gladly destroy any cultist who appears before him. That bit of information should be useful.”

“…Thank you for your answer.” Vanna hesitated for a moment, then still nodded very earnestly.

“Anything else you want to know?” Duncan asked again.

Vanna pressed her lips together.

Of course she did. But when it came to the wavering of her own faith and the matter of Subspace, she did not know if asking this ghost captain was the right choice.

In the end, she still did not mention her present confusion and doubt. Instead she asked a question related to herself in a roundabout way: "…I want to know whether Subspace responds to Mortal wishes—and what price is needed for the answer to that question."

Vanna deliberately stressed the word "price" at the end. She knew this question was completely different from their earlier talk.

Their earlier conversation had not touched on any knowledge in the supernatural realm. But this question… was an attempt to seek forbidden knowledge from a Shadow that had returned from Subspace. That was already a dangerous move.

She was not afraid to pay a price. She only wanted to know what that price would be.

"No need to be so tense. There is no price," Duncan said with a laugh in the mirror. "Because I'm really not close to them."

Vanna: "…Huh?"

"Why does everyone think I know all kinds of secrets about Subspace?" Duncan rubbed his forehead, a little helpless. "It's true that I've been there, but I wasn't doing a population survey in Subspace. You live in a neighborhood—does that mean you know every single person on the street?"

Vanna nodded. "I do."

Duncan: "…"

Vanna realized at once what she had just said. A little embarrassed and a little slow on the uptake, she added: “Of course, there might be people I don’t know so well… All right, I get your point.”

“I can’t answer your question, but I can see it’s tied to how bad you felt just now,” Duncan said, his expression turning serious again. “Has something from Subspace latched onto you?”

Vanna gave Duncan in the mirror a strange look.

Duncan thought for a moment, then added: “I mean besides me…”

“I don’t know.” Vanna shook her head. She opened her mouth as if to say more, but in the end said nothing.

“All right. It seems you still have some concerns. I understand,” Duncan said, not at all offended. “But if something from Subspace really is giving you trouble, you can ask me for help—at least in that realm, I can do something for you.”

Vanna fell silent. After more than ten seconds, she suddenly broke the silence. “Why?”

“You’re asking why I’m willing to help you?” Duncan’s voice came from the mirror. To Vanna it still sounded stern and a little gloomy, but now there was a touch of warmth and sincerity in it. “Maybe because we once fought side by side in Pland—Vanna, I admire your resolve and your courage.”

The figure in the mirror stood up.

The ghost captain seemed ready to leave.

Vanna let out a small breath of relief. She could not even say whether it was caution or simple nervousness at work right now, but his intent to leave did make her relax a little.

But just as Duncan’s figure was about to fade completely from the mirror, she seemed to recall something and suddenly spoke: “Wait, one more thing.”

Duncan turned his head slightly. “Hm?”

“In the future…” Vanna stumbled over her words, took a moment to gather them, then spoke with some hesitation. “I mean, if you plan to ‘appear’ again, could you maybe not do it so suddenly…”

Duncan did not answer at once. His face was wrapped in the Shadows deep in the mirror, and she could not see his expression.

After a few seconds, Vanna finally heard his voice reach her ears: “Next time, I’ll knock.”

Chapter 224: The Captain Never Left

The figure in the mirror had really left. He did nothing extra; just as he said at the start, he had only come over to “take a look at the situation.”

Vanna stared warily at the mirror for a long time before she finally confirmed this and truly relaxed.

Then she fell into a brief spell of self-reflection and uneasy suspicion.

The suspicion came from an Inquisitor’s professional habits. It was hard for her to truly trust a “person” like Captain Duncan, who carried a century of terrifying legends and was tied to Subspace. Even if he did seem rational and friendly, and had indeed protected the city-state of Pland, it was still hard. The self-reflection had a simpler cause—

She realized that during her talks with Captain Duncan, her vigilance had gradually weakened.

This was a weakness she should not have shown. She had never thought something like this would happen to her.

In the end, it was because she had fallen into wavering and self-doubt. She had lost the purity of her faith, and that had opened holes in her mind.

Vanna examined herself for a long time. In the end, she let out a soft sigh.

No matter what, the city had survived safely. She would report tonight’s events to Bishop Valentine, including… her own wavering.

The young Inquisitor’s sigh faded into the darkness together with the extinguished light.

…

On the second floor of the antique shop in the Lower City, Duncan pulled back his gaze from Pland’s great Cathedral. Looking at the night view of the city-state, with lights in countless homes near and far, a thoughtful look appeared on his face.

He did not know what had happened to Vanna, but one thing was clear. The young Inquisitor’s mental state had just gone through a brief yet dangerous shake. That wavering had even touched his senses directly, forcing him to project himself into the Mortal Realm to see what was happening to Vanna.

Thinking back now, the aura he had felt on Vanna then was faintly familiar. It hid deep in her spiritual world, wrapped around her. If he tried to tell it apart carefully, it felt a bit like…

…like that strange feeling he had when he stood in the hold of the Vanished and, through the cracks, watched the chaotic lights and shadows outside the hull.

It was Subspace.

And judging from the question Vanna had suddenly asked him at the end, her trouble was probably really related to Subspace.

Duncan tapped the windowsill with his fingers without thinking, guessing at the truth.

Before leaving, he had reinforced the mark he left on her. That power should be able to help her resist any coming corruption when needed. But the key question was this: why would a high-ranking Saint like Vanna suddenly show a trace of Subspace on her?

Duncan’s thoughts spread out. He suddenly connected this to some other clues—or rather, to some “knowledge.” Under certain conditions, the souls of Believers in the Four Gods were more easily corrupted by Subspace than Mortals. After they were corrupted, their souls could even directly generate a rift linking the Mortal Realm to Subspace. In that small Cathedral in the Sixth District, the first invasion had started from the Shadows of that Nun’s soul…

Would something similar appear on Vanna? If so, what lay behind this strange, counterintuitive phenomenon?

After a moment of thought, Duncan let out a breath and turned away from the window.

In any case, he should pay more attention in the future to this special “Node” that was Vanna. Right now Vanna still did not trust him, this “ghost captain,” so of course she would not take the initiative to tell him all her secrets. That meant he had to put in more effort on his side.

On the way back to his bedroom, Duncan heard the giggling voices of two young girls coming from the nearby room. It was Nina and Shirley.

Even though they had already returned from the Vanished to the city-state, they still seemed excited, especially Nina.

That child did not seem to have any psychological Shadows left by the eerie, frightening ghost ship, nor any uneasiness about the future. She was as cheerful as always, maybe even… a bit more cheerful.

Was it the influence of the Sun’s fragment? Or was it because she herself had a strong ability to accept new things?

Duncan grew thoughtful. He suddenly felt as if he had discovered some unexpected “talents” in Nina.

The veil of night hung low, and the cold, pale radiance of the World's Wound lit up the wide deck of the Vanished.

Light footsteps broke the silence on the ghost ship under the night. A figure in a gorgeous long dress, silver hair draped over her shoulders, walked up to the helm at the stern.

Alice lifted her head and looked at the captain holding the wheel himself. The glow reflected in her light violet eyes, making them shine: "Captain! Where are we going next?"

"We don't have a destination for now. We'll just leave the busy route between the city-states," Duncan lowered his head to glance at the doll. "You look to be in a good mood."

"Yeah, yeah!" Alice nodded happily. No matter how elegant and noble she looked, the eager way she nodded made her seem a bit silly. "The ship was so lively today! It's the first time I realized that just having a lot of people together can be so fun…"

"It's not always 'fun' when you bring people together—but that might be hard for you to understand right now," Duncan said offhand. "Also, control how hard you nod. You scared them half to death today when your head fell off."

"Oh, oh…" Alice hurriedly held her head with both hands, then suddenly looked a little worried. "Then they… won't stop coming because of that, right?"

"That worry is unnecessary."

Alice answered with another "oh," then stayed quiet for less than two seconds before asking again: "Then… can I still go to the city-state to play in the future? This time I went there, I didn't even get to really see the world before all that… messy stuff happened. It made me feel dizzy."

Duncan's gaze swept across the sea, then returned to Alice. "Of course you can. Tomorrow I can have AI send you to the antique shop—I still need you to help over there in the store."

"Really?" Alice's eyes clearly lit up. She seemed surprised. "I thought… we wouldn't go back to the city-state much anymore. After all… it felt like you had finished what you needed to do over there."

Duncan did not answer right away. He stayed silent on purpose for a few seconds before suddenly asking: "Do you think I only pay attention to Pland because I have some task I must do there?"

Alice froze for a moment, then slowly scratched her head. "I… don't know."

Duncan smiled and shook his head, gently letting go of the wheel.

Soft creaks came from all over the Vanished. The spirit form sails on the mast furled in a little. The ship shifted into the "cruising state" under Goathead's control.

"We only solved the trouble caused by a group of cultists," Duncan stepped down from the helm and walked toward the captain's cabin, speaking casually to Alice as he went. "As for Pland… I think that city-state has a connection with me."

The captain walked away. Alice stayed where she was, puzzling over his words for a while. Then she looked in the direction he had gone. "…As expected of the captain. So deep…"

Duncan came to the door of the captain's cabin. He looked up and saw the words "The Lost Ones" carved on the doorframe, reflecting the dim radiance from the World's Wound.

He drew in a slow breath to steady his mind, then put his hand on the doorknob.

He gently pushed it open.

Hazy, twisted mist appeared before his eyes. Duncan stepped forward and felt the familiar instant of weightlessness and slight dizziness. That sense of dislocation, as if he were crossing endless time and space yet also arriving at his destination in a single moment, flashed by. Then everything around him grew quiet.

The never-ending wind and waves of the Boundless Sea and the faint creaking of the Vanished faded away. The salty sea breeze quietly vanished. A familiar smell filled the air, from the room he had lived in for many years.

Zhou Ming opened his eyes and looked at the unchanging scene in his studio apartment.

As always, the first thing he did after coming back here was check the general state of the room. He checked whether anything had changed while he was gone, whether there was any sign that the thick fog outside the window had thinned, and whether the strings and bits of paper he had left on the window and windowsill had been moved.

Even though he knew it was pointless, he still treated this series of “checks” as a task he had to complete.

After he finished all of that, the second thing he did was walk to his desk.

Zhou Ming lowered his head and calmly looked at the thing on his desk.

A city-state of Pland, like a scaled-down model, sat quietly on the desktop.

It was exquisite and faithful. Every tiny detail was vividly reproduced. It might even match every paving stone and every lamppost of the real Pland.

In other words, this was the real Pland shown in his apartment in some kind of “projection” form.

Its appearance here was exactly what he had expected.

The fine flames that had once leaped and burned on the desk had finished the last carving of this “collection piece.” Now this perfect masterpiece stood before its master.

Zhou Ming let out a soft breath, slowly sat down by the desk, and studied the delicate “model.”

Compared to the “model” of the Vanished, this “city-state” was clearly much larger, but it certainly wasn’t a simple scaled-up version. Its size seemed just right to fit into a single compartment on the shelf, as if it had been made exactly for that spot.

And in this lifelike city model, he could not see any trace of residents.

It seemed that the “people” living in the city-state could not form projections here.

Zhou Ming grew thoughtful and, after pondering and studying the model of Pland again and again for a long time, finally let out a light breath. He picked up the large “collection piece” with both hands and carefully placed it on the nearby shelf.

After he set it in place, he stepped back two paces and quietly admired his new collection.

The Vanished had already sailed far away from Pland, but the captain… had never left his loyal city-state.

Chapter 225: The Late Sunrise

After putting his new “collection piece” in place, Zhou Ming did not leave the room as usual. Instead, he sat down in the chair opposite the shelf, looking at the Vanished and Pland on it while he fell into thought.

He was trying to sum up and understand what these “collection pieces” meant.

All along, this studio apartment and the world beyond the door had been completely cut off from each other. Only he could pass through that door. Nothing from either world could cross the fog barrier in the doorway. He had tested this many times.

In a way, the models of the Vanished and Pland that appeared in the room had already broken that rule. They clearly had a link to the world beyond the door, and their nature obviously had… “supernatural properties.”

“supernatural” was not supposed to be a concept that appeared on this side of the door.

The two collection pieces both followed a common rule. They were things that had been completely burned by the spirit form fire and then consciously “claimed” by him.

Zhou Ming thought quietly and slowly summed up the pattern. In the end, he decided that “burning” and “claiming” were indeed the two necessary conditions for a collection piece to appear.

The White Oak had once also been burned to ashes by the Vanished's flames, but at that time he had not actively tried to claim that ship. He had not placed any influence or "orders" on the White Oak. So after the burning, that ship only left behind a strong mark and did not form a matching "collection piece" in the room on this side of the door.

The city-state of Pland had been burned away by spirit flame, and in the burning he had actively taken control of the city-state and carried out purification, even treating it as part of the Vanished. So Pland had become a collection piece here.

Then… what use could this transformation have? What meaning did these things, turned into collection pieces, have for him?

Zhou Ming's gaze fell on the model of Pland. Then he slowly closed his eyes.

A breeze was blowing over the Harbor district in the southeast of the city-state. Small waves lapped at the shore. The clock tower in the Fourth District had just chimed for the last time, and the steam factories in the Upper City were roaring as they ran.

He opened his eyes again. Things were just as he had expected.

He could sense the state of the entire city-state, down to any building and any streetlight. Although he could not sense the parts that belonged to the "people" in the city-state, the true body of Pland lay before him just like that lifelike model, fully displayed in his mind.

This feeling… was just like his control over the Vanished.

Zhou Ming grew thoughtful and rubbed his chin with his fingers without realizing it. Once he understood just how far his influence over the city-state reached, he naturally began to use the Vanished as a reference.

The Pland of now could already be seen as another Vanished. So whatever he could do on the Vanished, he could undoubtedly do in Pland as well.

He could order every clock tower in the city-state to ring for him, order the city-state to sink into the Spirit Realm, and even…

Zhou Ming stopped rubbing his chin.

…even order the city-state to sink into Subspace.

Zhou Ming's eyes narrowed. He quickly pulled back and crushed that terrifying thought that had suddenly appeared, but even though he suppressed it, his heart still pounded.

He really could do that, because he could also make the Vanished do it. Subspace was right there. He could clearly sense the "position" of that chaotic dimension. That "promised land" that the Enders longed for yet could never reach felt to him almost like going home…

And not just that. When that frightening idea had just popped into his mind, he immediately felt a faint call, like the strange urge some people feel to jump when they stand on a cliff edge. He had just felt that same urge!

With just one thought, one command, one moment of giving in to that urge, one careless slip, he… could reach the place that was calling him.

At the same time, he would drag down with him anything swept up by him, ruled by him, or corrupted by him, all falling together.

Zhou Ming took a deep breath and slowly stood up from the chair.

The world was right to be deeply afraid of the Vanished and Captain Duncan. People should be afraid.

Zhou Ming gave his collection shelf one last, long look, let out a heavy breath, then turned and walked toward the apartment door.

On the table that held the enchanted sea chart in the captain's cabin, the dark wooden carving of Goathead heard the sound at the door. It lifted its head and saw Duncan's tall figure appear at the doorway. Its eyes, carved from obsidian, lit up at once, and it immediately began to chatter fluently: "Ah! The great captain has returned to his loyal First Mate! Your achievements are known to all, your mighty power makes the Boundless Sea…"

Duncan said nothing. He sat down beside the chart table and silently watched Goathead babble on, his expression calm.

In the end it was Goathead who began to feel awkward first. Halfway through its "blah-blah-blah," it could not help stopping. "Uh… Captain, don't you usually say 'shut up' at this point?"

Duncan's face stayed calm. "I just suddenly got curious about how long you could keep talking if I didn't tell you to shut up."

Goathead perked up at once. It seemed not to hear the teasing in Duncan's words at all, or it heard and pretended not to. "Then you hit the nail on the head! Your loyal First Mate here is always learned and well-informed. Even if we only talk about recipes on the Boundless Sea, I can go on from morning to night. If you are interested, we can start with the one hundred and thirty-seven types of butter cookies—"

"All right, shut up," Duncan quickly cut him off, shaking his head helplessly. "I thought you at least had some concept of feeling awkward."

Goathead shook its head, its neck creaking. Then its pitch-black face finally turned fully toward Duncan, and its empty eye sockets stared at his face. "Captain, you look like something is on your mind. We just finished an unprecedented feat. What could still affect your mood?"

“An unprecedented feat…” Duncan muttered softly, then shook his head. “You can feel it, right? The connection between the city-state of Pland and the Vanished now.”

“Of course!” Goathead answered at once, not forgetting to flatter him. “I never thought there would be such a day—your might is shocking. This time your prey is an entire city-state! So where is the next target? Shall we go to Lunsa first, or Cold Harbor? Or maybe Frostholm as well—”

Duncan waved his hand, and Goathead fell silent at once.

“I’m not interested in ‘prey’ for now. I just want to tell you that I don’t have the energy to watch such a huge place all the time. If you sense something that shouldn’t appear stepping into Pland, you can alert me—of course, only if you have the spare strength. Your main job is still to look after this ship.”

“With pleasure!” Goathead said at once. “That’s easy for me. I definitely won’t let you down…”

Duncan nodded lightly. Then his gaze swept over the Chronometer Clock on the nearby wall and shifted to the window.

Before he knew it, the night had already passed.

A few seconds later, Duncan suddenly turned his head. “What time is it now?!”

Goathead froze for a moment, not quite sure. “It should… be morning, right? The Sun should be rising.”

“…The Sun has not risen,” Duncan said in a deep voice, his expression unusually serious. Then he suddenly turned his head again, staring hard at the ticking Chronometer Clock. “…Sunrise should have been fourteen minutes ago.”

Goathead fell silent at once. Duncan's eyes stayed fixed on the hands of the Chronometer Clock as they moved step by step, and on the mechanical disk at the top of the clock that marked the Sun's rise.

In this world, the "Sun," the super Vision numbered 001, rose every day at a perfectly precise time and set at a perfectly precise time. The Vanished's Chronometer Clock was linked to the coordinates on the enchanted sea chart and could precisely show at what hour and minute Vision 001 would leap above the sea in the current waters. Since Duncan had come to this world, none of this had ever gone wrong.

Today, the Sun had not risen on time. An ordinary person might not have noticed this change yet, but Duncan had, and the instant he noticed it he suddenly felt a huge… unease.

He did not even know where this unease had suddenly come from.

"Maybe… we just need to wait a little…" Goathead's voice sounded again then. It seemed a little nervous too. "You see, the weather at sea is always unpredictable. Maybe something is blocking—"

But Duncan was not listening to what Goathead was saying. He was still watching the Chronometer Clock. In the next second, however, a faint ray of golden light suddenly appeared at the edge of his vision.

That ray of gold had shone in through the window.

Duncan turned around at once, took a few quick steps to the window, pushed it open, and looked out over the distant sea.

The Sun had risen. The huge glowing orb, bound by two layers of rune rings, slowly climbed into the sky as always. Its blazing light shone over the entire Boundless Sea and at the same time drove away the cold, pale cast that the World's Wound left on this world.

He looked back and checked the time one last time.

Today’s sunrise was fifteen minutes later than usual.

Why?

Was it the aftershock of the disaster in Pland? Was it related to the “Creeping Sun Wheel” that the Suntists had summoned? Was it tied to Nina’s awakening and control? Or… was it the sign of another anomaly still to come?

Duncan went back to the table, his thoughts running wild in spite of himself. He knew he might be worrying too much, but after just going through that historic corruption crisis in Pland, he was now especially alert to every unusual sign.

“Maybe it’s just the influence of the weather at sea. Look, the Sun still came up,” Goathead said beside him. “Sometimes large areas of thick fog can refract the light and make—”

“The sunlight in Pland was also fifteen minutes late,” Duncan quietly cut Goathead off. “The weather over there is clear, and the sea is calm. What was late wasn’t the sunlight. It was the Sun itself.”

“…What the hell.”

Chapter 226: The Shaken

Hurried footsteps broke the silence of the great cathedral. Archbishop Valentine, who had been assigning tasks to a Deacon at his side, heard the sound and looked up. He saw Vanna walking straight toward him.

The Archbishop waved for the Deacon and the attendant to step back for now. His gaze fell on Vanna: “I thought you would rest at home for a few more days.”

“Unfortunately, it seems I do not have that luxury,” Vanna shook her head, her expression slightly grave. “What happened? I saw many priests rushing about, and I heard a group of ascetic Monks were sent down into the Stargazing Well… Is it related to today’s sunrise?”

“Yes,” Valentine nodded, his face solemn. “Today’s sunrise was fifteen minutes later than usual—and it was not a local Anomaly in the sky delaying dawn. I have received Psychic Transmissions from other city-states and from communication Nodes at sea. Everywhere in the world, they observed the same Anomaly.”

“…This world was exposed to the World’s Wound for fifteen extra minutes…” Vanna’s brow slowly furrowed. “Are there any damage reports yet?”

“No. A single delayed dawn is not enough to cause trouble. Fifteen minutes of veil of night is still within the city’s margin of safety,” the old Archbishop shook his head. “What truly worries us is that the whole world

saw the same phenomenon. That means the problem is not on the surface or at sea."

"…It means the operation of Vision 001 itself has changed." Of course Vanna knew what the old Archbishop was worried about. "There is no notice from the tomb of the Nameless King?"

Valentine shook his head lightly.

"There has been no movement at all. So this might only be a small… 'shift', not a fundamental change in Vision 001. But… I fear most people will not be reassured that easily. We at least need to see the Sun set normally today, and see the Sun rise normally tomorrow, before we dare to relax a little."

Vanna fell silent, thinking. After a moment she asked: "Have the ordinary people in the city been affected?"

"For now, there is no great unrest," Valentine said. "Some people did not even notice that fifteen-minute delay, and the citizens who did notice probably do not understand how serious it is. I have already sent a letter to City Hall, asking them to assess whether we should later issue comforting, mental guidance notices. Right now the impact is still limited. If the authorities explain too eagerly, it may instead unsettle the public—especially after the great disaster we just went through."

Vanna listened quietly to the old Archbishop's analysis and did not interrupt. As an Inquisitor who put most of her energy into combat missions, she knew she was not an expert on such matters. She only showed a thoughtful look from time to time, which made it clear that she was not as calm as she appeared.

Valentine saw the faint worry between her brows: "What are you thinking about?"

“I am just a little emotional,” Vanna sighed softly and shook her head. “Every time there is an supernatural disaster, I feel more how fragile the world we live in really is… The city-states, the Holy See, the ocean-going warships, everything we are proud of, all seem to stand on a thin, fragile layer of ice. If any crack goes unnoticed, we will vanish from this world…”

“That is exactly why we must always remain vigilant and strong,” Valentine said in a low voice, and he met the young Inquisitor’s eyes with a steady gaze. “Vanna, you rarely talk like this… What happened?”

Vanna fell silent. After a few seconds, as if making up her mind, she said to Archbishop Valentine: “There are two things. The first is… I met that ‘Captain Duncan’ again yesterday.”

Valentine’s eyes first grew grave, but after a moment he let out a soft sigh: “In fact, that was within expectations.”

He paused, then went on: “We still have no way to deal with the mark that ghost captain left on you. Now even the entire city-state of Pland may already be in contact with that captain. It was only a matter of time before he came to you. What did he say to you?”

“…Mostly small talk,” Vanna said, sounding slightly strange.

“…Small talk?” This time Valentine finally raised his brows in surprise. “You mean, the captain of the Vanished, the Shadow who returned from Subspace, the ‘Duncan’ who reversed historical corruption and took away a fragment of the Sun—he sought you out just to have small talk?”

“I knew you would react like that—I could hardly believe it myself. Honestly, if he had told me he had a plan to conquer the world, I would have believed him, but…” Vanna sighed. Then, over the next ten minutes or so, she told the old man every detail of her conversation with Duncan the previous night.

Valentine rubbed his forehead as he listened to Vanna's account. This old Archbishop, who had not wavered even in the face of a Doomsday crisis, now showed undisguised trouble and weariness on his face.

But after that brief look of confusion, he still raised his head. His tone was somewhat complicated as he said: "Vanna, since last night I have been pondering a question."

"What question?"

"…You are the one who has spoken with Captain Duncan directly twice. In your view, does that 'ghost captain'… seem like an Intruder from Subspace?"

"You… what do you mean?" Vanna's expression shifted slightly as she asked carefully. "The Vanished falling into Subspace and returning has clear…"

"I am not doubting that," Valentine cut in. "Of course I know the records of the Vanished returning from Subspace. I am asking you to recall: what state should a person be in when they are completely affected by Subspace? And… is it possible for a true Subspace Intruder to talk to people rationally, and in doing so not cause uncontrolled corruption?"

This time Vanna hesitated. She could not answer as quickly as before. After several seconds of doubt, she finally spoke: "Judging from all the cases and our basic knowledge of Subspace… that is impossible."

"When we perform a Sanity Check on those corrupted by the deep layers, we use a simple and effective rule of thumb—anyone who can still speak rationally is savable, or at least not completely transformed," Archbishop Valentine nodded. "Subspace corruption is extremely deadly. Because of this, in history there has never been a Subspace-corrupted person or Intruder who stayed clear-headed. Madness is a mark they cannot erase.

And perhaps… we can apply this simple rule to the Vanished and its captain as well."

"…You mean that 'Captain Duncan' is very likely still holding on to his humanity?"

"Or has taken it back," Archbishop Valentine corrected calmly. "In the early records, there are clear reports of the Vanished launching indiscriminate attacks, and of Captain Duncan falling into madness. At that time he clearly matched the standard of a Subspace Intruder."

Vanna thought it over, and the more she thought, the more disbelief showed on her face: "Is this possible? After being completely transformed by Subspace corruption… to somehow take back one's humanity, this…"

"If it were impossible, how would you explain the Captain Duncan who 'chatted' with you?" Archbishop Valentine gently cut her off. Then he paused and reminded her: "Do not forget the Clause Zero Law."

Vanna froze for a moment, then reacted: "There are always Anomalies and Visions that do not fit our understanding or go beyond our definitions…"

The great cathedral fell silent again. No one knew how long that silence lasted before Valentine suddenly spoke: "But we still cannot use this to treat the Vanished and its captain as harmless, do you understand?

"After all, that ship returned from Subspace. Even if that captain has taken back his humanity, it is hard to say from what kind of viewpoint he now looks at us… 'mortals'."

"And we also cannot make a rash judgment on our own. We must report all the information we have to the Pope, Her Eminence, and see how she views this matter."

Vanna straightened her expression and nodded at once, her face solemn: "Of course. I understand that very well."

Then she paused, her expression a little odd: “Talking about such things in this holy cathedral really… puts pressure on the heart. In the past, I might have branded myself a ‘Heretic’ for it.”

Valentine only let out a noncommittal sigh, then asked again: “You said there were two things. Besides meeting that ghost captain, what is the second one?”

This time, Vanna stayed silent for much longer. She seemed to struggle with herself, then finally, under the gaze of the statue of the storm goddess Gamona, she gathered all her courage and said solemnly to the old Archbishop: “I… should confess.”

“Confess?” Valentine looked at her in surprise. “Why do you need to confess?”

“I wavered—though I am still devout, I cannot deny my moment of weakness,” Vanna took a deep breath and admitted bluntly. “After that great fire, I began to question my faith.”

She laid out her doubts about the Goddess and the shakiness of her own belief. Aside from keeping back the secret her uncle had told her, she did not hide anything.

The old Archbishop did not speak for a long time.

Vanna watched the old man’s face with some unease, yet this time she found she could not read Valentine’s attitude at all.

He seemed lost in thought, as if he wanted to speak yet held back, and there was no blame in his eyes.

After what felt like a long time, Vanna finally heard his voice reach her ears.

“Vanna, you came to me to confess… then who should I go to for my confession?”

A trace of surprise finally appeared in Vanna’s eyes.

“Now, there are two whose faith has wavered in this great cathedral,” the old Archbishop turned and gazed quietly at the statue of the storm goddess. The cold stone figure looked down on him, as silent as always. His voice carried a strange calm. “Vanna, can you feel it?”

“Feel what?”

“…The Goddess is still blessing us.”

Chapter 227: The Aftershocks Remained

The wavering of a devout believer often came twice. The first time was when they began to doubt their own faith. The second was when they had already doubted, yet the God still sent down divine blessings.

Noise—fine layers of noise, sometimes near, sometimes far, faint yet undeniably there—started to sound in Vanna's mind, like ringing in her ears. She recalled again the projection of the Goddess she had seen in the vision, and those incomprehensible words the Goddess had spoken to her. She no longer accepted it all without thinking, as she had before. Instead she began to think seriously, to ponder the meaning of those words, even to try to guess Gamona's… intention.

The more she thought, the clearer that fine noise in her head became, making it hard to focus.

But suddenly all the noise vanished. She shook her head in a daze and found herself meeting Archbishop Valentine's concerned gaze.

"Are you all right?" the old man asked, a little worried.

"I… am fine," Vanna tapped her forehead lightly, then looked at her elder with a strange expression. "You also…"

"When I rang the last bell, I wavered… There is nothing to hide in that. In the end, I did not have a flawless will like the Saints recorded in the temple," Valentine shook his head and spoke frankly to Vanna. "I wondered

why the corruption and infiltration of those Enders could reach such a level. Why even the protection of the Great Cathedral could not stop the sacrificial rite of those Heretics of the Sun—why the crisis had spread for more than ten years, and yet the Goddess never warned us even once…"

He fell silent, then turned around and gazed quietly at Gamona's statue. The cold stone figure looked down on him, as silent as always.

"When I woke up again, I was filled with shame. I knew I had committed the greatest error named in the Storm Canon: treating the God's protection as a cure-all and so letting my own will waver. But even so, these doubts had already taken root, and they remain even now."

"…The enemy infiltrated from within and broke through the walls. They planned for many years. It was a sneak attack that was hard to resist," Vanna was silent for a moment, then spoke calmly. "Heretics always strike when there is a weakness. That does not mean the Goddess's divine authority can be easily overturned."

"I understand that," Valentine smiled. "That is why I say that even if I have wavered a little, I am still devout. The Goddess truly protects our world. Her mercy is real. It is just that… I have begun to think a bit more than before."

"Thought gives birth to heresy, Archbishop Valentine," Vanna said with a very serious face, but then she sighed, as if talking to herself. "It is the same for me."

"Then let us treat this as a trial," Valentine said softly. "For both of us."

Vanna said nothing more. She only walked to the statue of the Goddess, bowed her head slightly, and offered a silent benediction as she always did.

Not long after, footsteps suddenly broke the silence in the great cathedral.

Vanna snapped out of her benediction and looked toward the sound. She saw a middle-aged priest in civil robes striding over. The priest first saluted the statue, then handed a document to Valentine: “Archbishop, this is the report you requested.”

Valentine nodded his thanks and took the file. After quickly flipping through a few pages, his expression became visibly strange.

“What is it?” Vanna asked at once, curious when she saw his face. “What does it say?”

“…It is the initial survey of the city’s situation after the disaster… from City Hall,” Valentine frowned, as if hesitating. But in the end he simply handed the file to Vanna. “See for yourself.”

Vanna took the file in puzzlement. From the first lines she knew what it was —a preliminary damage report, something she knew well. It checked whether any parts of the city-state were missing or changed after the disaster, whether there were people missing or “additional” people, whether any areas still held residual supernatural power… The first part held nothing special. It basically stated that all parts of the city had been reset to their state before the disaster. But the later pages instantly told her why Archbishop Valentine’s expression had looked so odd.

“…In the dock district, several merchants report large quantities of French fries mysteriously disappearing. The loss report even lists ketchup…” The young Inquisitor lifted her head with a blank expression and looked at Valentine, whose face was just as blank. “…Seriously?”

“Maybe you should personally take a team and ask about it?” Valentine’s mouth twitched. “In theory, no one would dare falsify a report like this.”

Vanna held the report in her hands for a long time without saying a word.

After holding it in for a long while, she finally muttered: “Why would something like this appear in such a serious report…”

Valentine’s face stayed blank: “An entire company of Guardians has been watching those fries on the dock—what do you think?”

Vanna: “…”

“…In short, the ‘items’ mentioned in the report are the only known loss in the city so far,” Valentine sighed. Then he seemed to hesitate again, and finally looked Vanna in the eyes. “Next time you meet him, why not ask directly?”

Vanna blinked: “Ask? Ask who?”

“…What do you think?”

Vanna: “…”

After a moment, the young Inquisitor finally rubbed her forehead: “I feel like my thoughts are starting to break apart. Let me confirm—we were supposed to be discussing very serious matters here, right?”

“I cannot keep up either,” Valentine said, face stiff.

Vanna had no words, but a strange thought suddenly came to her—if this was also one of that ghost captain’s “effects”, then he really was terrifying in a certain sense.

Just then, more footsteps suddenly sounded at the door, cutting off Vanna and Valentine’s thoughts again—a priest hurried to the statue.

“Archbishop, Inquisitor, there is news from the Harbor district…”

The priest bowed and began to speak quickly, but halfway through, Vanna heard the words “Harbor district” and could not help interrupting him:

“Stop. We already know about the fries. You do not need to report that twice!”

“…Fries?” The priest stared in confusion at the Inquisitor, who was usually so calm and dignified. “What fries?”

“Ah… you were not going to report about the fries?” Seeing his reaction, Vanna felt a sudden wave of embarrassment. She quickly coughed twice to cover it up. “I thought it was another report… Never mind. Go on. What happened in the Harbor district?”

As she spoke, she could not help sighing inwardly: [It is fine as long as it is not about fries—at least it does not involve that terrifying ghost captain again.]

The reporting priest nodded, face stern: “News from the Harbor district: The Sea Mist is requesting permission to enter port—Tyrian Abnomar hopes to make contact with the Great Cathedral as soon as possible. He brings news related to the Vanished.”

Vanna immediately erupted into a fit of coughing loud enough to shake the hall.

The priest jumped at the noise: “…Lady Inquisitor?”

“I am fine,” Vanna finally managed to stop coughing after great effort. Ever since the Vanished had openly made a circuit around the city-state, she felt as if nothing in this place was quite the same. She could not say exactly how, but it seemed that many things around her were changing—she even wanted to blame the fifteen-minute-late sunrise on that ghost ship. “The Sea Mist? I know we did send a letter to its master, but it never arrived…”

“The Sea Mist did arrive, and it seems it was already near Pland’s coastal waters before the ‘disaster’,” the priest nodded at once. “But according to the message from the ship, it ran into the Vanished by accident in the

eastern waters and fought a fierce battle. Its engines were damaged and it had to undergo repairs. Only last night did it regain the ability to sail."

"It fought a battle with the Vanished?!" Vanna's expression finally turned stern as she grasped how important this was. She turned to Valentine: "I need to go there myself."

"Very well," Valentine nodded at once. "The Sea Mist is a special ship. It is indeed 'one of ours', but its crew may still cause fear and unease among the ordinary people on the docks. If you personally lead a team to receive them, you should be able to calm the people's nerves."

Vanna gave a brief answer and strode out of the great cathedral.

The Sea Mist had come—arriving a bit later than expected, but the huge warship wrapped in legendary glory and fearful tales of the curse still reached the city-state of Pland that had sent the distress call, just as agreed. Now the awe-inspiring Ironclad Warship was slowly approaching the pier reserved for large vessels, guided in by mental guidance officers on the docks. Some people who had heard the news gathered near the harbor, watching the steel giant with tense curiosity.

Soon, the people near the docks realized that this mighty Ironclad Warship had reached the Harbor only after a brutal battle.

It was covered in scars. Three of its six main guns were simply gone. All along the hull, there were terrifying gaps where something had torn whole chunks away. A third of the bridge had been destroyed, and a dreadful wound ran from the side of the bridge all the way down to the main armored belt. Even near the waterline, on the ship's flank, several horrible holes could be seen.

Damage like this would have been enough to sink an ordinary warship several times over.

Yet The Sea Mist still floated stubbornly on the waves. The holes in her belly seemed alive. Soft, metal-sheened substance had sealed the leaks tight, and the seawater that had seeped into the lower decks was being pushed back out. The Sea Mist's pumps had already shut down, so the water was actually oozing straight through the sides of the hull, as if… a person were sweating.

It was an advanced Ironclad Warship, and also a cursed ship full of Anomalies. Everyone standing near the docks could clearly see the "living" traits the ship displayed. Their curiosity gained a new layer of horror, and whispers spread everywhere among the onlookers.

Only when several imposing Steam Walkers appeared on the docks, and Vanna's tall figure came into view, did many people finally quiet down.

Chapter 228: The Pirate Lord Enters the City-State

The Steam Walker stopped in front of the pier. Vanna stood on the shell of the spider-like machine and lifted her head to study the legendary vessel before her, the ship reputed to be an Unsinkable Warship.

It was unsinkable, not invincible. Perhaps this ship really was hard to sink, but that did not mean it could not be beaten until it was covered in wounds.

To the naked eye, it was clear that the Sea Mist had gone through a brutal battle. Of course, if she thought back to how the Vanished had looked completely unscathed when she saw it from the top of the Great Bell, one could also say that this Ironclad Warship before her had simply been beaten up one-sidedly. Vanna did not really know much about ships, but she did know how unbelievable it was for a vessel in this condition to still drift safely into the Harbor.

And this was already after the Sea Mist had spent a full day and night using its powerful “unsinkable” ability to repair itself.

Memories of the Vanished surfaced in her mind, along with the curse-like connection between herself and Captain Duncan. Vanna felt a headache coming on. She rubbed her temples and jumped down from the Steam Walker to the ground. At the same time, she saw that a long gangplank had been lowered from the side of the Sea Mist not far away, and several figures were appearing on it.

At their head was a one-eyed man wearing a stern captain's uniform. His slightly wavy black hair framed a face that resembled Duncan Abnomar's by a few parts out of ten. Yet compared to that ghost captain with the suffocating presence, Captain Tyrian, now walking toward the pier, looked rather tired.

Behind this famed pirate captain were several attendants. Their skin was deathly pale, and the expressions on their faces were like frozen plaster statues, faintly carrying some inhuman quality. Yet overall, they were not as terrifying as the horror tales made such beings sound.

Vanna had heard many rumors about the Sea Mist. Because it more or less still counted as a ship belonging to Human civilization, the stories about it were naturally richer and more detailed than those about the Vanished. And in those tales, what people mentioned most often were the Undying Sailors under Tyrian Abnomar.

It was said that these Sailors were the subordinates Tyrian had taken with him when he defected and left Frostholm. Some of them were even veterans who had belonged to the Vanished's fleet a century ago. Like their captain, they had been affected by Subspace. The curse clinging to the members of the Abnomar family had leaked onto their followers, turning them into ageless, undying Living dead.

They could not die within the dimensions of the Mortal Realm, nor could they enjoy the warmth of the Mortal Realm as the living did. They could not feel a moment of peace in the world of the living, yet they could not step through the Gate of Rest belonging to God of Death Bartok either.

In other rumors, people said these Living dead Sailors no longer held any attachment to the mortal world or to their former companions. Only certain ancient and powerful oaths bound them, forcing them to serve their Master, the eldest son of the Abnomar family, for all eternity.

Vanna stared fixedly at those figures as they stepped onto the soil of the city-state of Pland and, led by Tyrian, walked toward her.

Living dead. Strictly speaking, they already counted as subjects of God of Death Bartok, and Bartok, along with the other Three Gods, belonged to the camp of the True Gods. So these Living dead Sailors were allowed to step onto the soil of the city-state. That did not mean, however, that an ordinary person could accept these horrifying “former compatriots” so easily. And given how closely these Living dead Sailors were tied to the Abnomar family’s curse, Vanna had to keep a constant eye on their every move.

Only… this city-state of Pland, which had just been burned through completely by the Vanished’s flames, was it really so different from these Sailors who had gained eternal life because of the curse?

This troubling question popped up in Vanna’s mind despite herself, and while she was distracted for just that moment, the one-eyed pirate captain had already come to stand before her.

Tyrian took off his captain’s hat and bent slightly in a bow as he said: “Greetings, Inquisitor.”

He was surprised by Vanna’s youth and her height of a meter ninety, but he did not show it at all. His manners were so proper that he looked nothing like a terrifying Pirate Lord, but rather like a naval Commander still loyal to some city-state. “Thank you for coming to receive us in person.”

Vanna quickly shook off her distraction, looked at the man before her, who seemed to be around thirty, and said: “It is good to meet you, Captain Tyrian.”

She instinctively compared him to the “Captain Duncan” she had seen and found that he was not as tall as Duncan and lacked some of that suffocating

authority. “You answered Pland’s call for aid. For that alone, the arrival of the Sea Mist deserves my personal welcome.”

Tyrian let out a sigh and said with a strange look: “Yet in the end we did not really come in handy.”

Then he instinctively lifted his head to look around the Harbor, as if searching for something.

Vanna had a vague idea, but she still asked casually: “What are you looking for?”

“Forgive my boldness, but did you receive the message we sent before making port?” Tyrian asked, a bit tense as he looked around. “We ran into the Vanished on the way. We tried our best to intercept it, but that ship still…”

“Your father has already been here,” Vanna said with a sigh. “He left just yesterday.”

As soon as she spoke, the Pirate Lord standing opposite her froze like a stone statue. Even the plaster-cold, rigid faces of the attendants behind him twitched.

“I… I did not quite hear that,” Tyrian finally reacted after a few seconds, staring at the young Inquisitor before him with a look as if he had seen a ghost. “Inquisitor, did you just say my father was here yesterday…”

He put particular emphasis on the word “father”, as if he feared Vanna might be making some deadly joke on that very point.

“The situation is complicated. We will need to explain it carefully,” Vanna sighed again. “The Vanished did appear, but what happened was completely different from what we described in the letter we first sent you. The city-state of Pland has just gone through a great… upheaval. Please come with me. Bishop Valentine is already waiting in the great Cathedral. We urgently

need all kinds of information, and I imagine you also have countless questions that need answers."

Tyrian felt that all the contingency plans he had worked out on the way here had just been thrown into chaos. He followed after Vanna almost in a daze, walking toward the Steam Walkers from the great Cathedral. A black Steam Car prepared specially for guests was already parked by the roadside, bearing the emblem of the Deep Sea Church.

As they walked toward the car, Tyrian suddenly spoke in a self-deprecating tone, perhaps to break the awkward mood, perhaps to ease some nameless pressure. For some reason, whenever he looked at Vanna he always felt a faint but constant pressure. "To be honest, I thought you would stop me in the dock district," he said. "After all, under normal circumstances, the city-state authorities either refuse a pirate entry or simply prepare a noose for the pirate."

"This is not Frostholm. The northern city-states' warrants against the Sea Mist do not reach as far as Pland, unless one day you make a truly 'big scene' and earn yourself a joint warrant from the entire Boundless Sea," Vanna said casually. "Before that happens, as far as Pland is concerned you are just a captain who kindly offered aid. And…"

As she spoke, she turned her head to glance at the Sea Mist. Even covered in scars, the ship still radiated a mighty presence.

"And honestly, even in the Northern Seas, is there really any city-state that could slip a noose around your neck the moment you made landfall?"

Tyrian thought about it, then laughed.

"When I go ashore, the city Guard Corps politely call me the boss of the 'Sea Mist Venture Company' and, whenever anyone questions it, they advertise my visit as a commercial exchange between the city-state and the

Sea Mist fleet," he said. "You know, pirates have a saying: the lowest-level warrant keeps the small-time pirates awake at night, a city-state-level warrant makes the Pirate Lords sit on pins and needles, and the highest-level warrants… are used by the person named on them to wipe tables and sword hilts."

The Pirate Lord paused, then said calmly: "Aside from Frostholm, I can set foot on any northern city-state's land with a clear conscience."

Vanna raised her eyebrows: "Aside from Frostholm?"

"Ray Nora, Her Majesty, ordered me to leave Frostholm," Tyrian said, the hint of a smile disappearing from his face. "She has not rescinded that order."

Vanna glanced at him and saw that, without her noticing, the Pirate Lord's expression had turned unusually serious.

She did not say anything more. She simply stopped at the corner and pointed to the guest car beside them: "Please get in, Captain Tyrian."

With that, she turned and jumped onto a nearby Steam Walker, standing on it as imposingly as ever.

Tyrian, meanwhile, turned and got into the car with several of his attendants.

The moment the car door closed, he let out a long breath.

"Captain," one attendant, noticing his reaction, could not help looking over curiously. "Are you all right? I felt you were a bit… tense just now. You are never that stiff even when dealing with other famous captains or city officials."

"I do not know why, but whenever I spoke to that young Inquisitor I kept feeling a… hard-to-describe pressure," Tyrian said. He did not hide his

feelings in front of his most trusted aides. “It was completely different from dealing with officials of other city-states. I did not feel such a strange pressure even that time we passed close by the Death Sanctuary on patrol.”

“Really?” The attendant frowned in puzzlement. “I did not feel anything… though that Inquisitor is indeed quite tall and looks rather formidable…”

“Not that kind of pressure,” Tyrian shook his head. “All right, do not keep talking about it. The power of a high-ranking Saint is extremely strong. She can hear what you are saying.”

At that, the attendant clamped his mouth shut at once.

Tyrian let out a small breath of relief and looked out the carriage window at the slowly shifting scenery of Pland with a complicated expression.

In his childhood, he and Lucretia had once stayed briefly in this city-state, but that had been a century ago. Now this Sea Jewel had become a completely unfamiliar land to him.

Chapter 229: The Blood-Seeking spirit compass

The Ironclad Warship lay quietly at anchor in Pland's Harbor. Above the warship, the flag of the Sea Mist fleet unfurled in the sunlight, fluttering in the wind. Its emblem was a cluster of ice crystals as sharp as blades, with a crack running through the center. The ice crystals were the symbol of Frostholm; the crack was the mark of a self-exiled rebel.

After the famed pirate captain and his attendants left, no one else disembarked from the warship. The Sea Mist was like a silent iceberg, lying quietly at anchor. Its towering, imposing hull and prow blocked all curious gazes from the docks. At the same time, a city-state Guard Corps detachment arrived from a nearby station and sealed off the road leading to the pier to keep unrelated people from approaching.

Only after a Constable personally came to disperse them did the gawkers gathered near the docks finally begin to drift away.

First Mate Aiden stood on the Sea Mist's bridge, quietly watching the activity on the pier.

He had not gone ashore with Tyrian. Whenever the captain left the warship, the First Mate had to stay on board to temporarily hold the captain's authority, in case anything went wrong.

"Those city Guard Corps look awfully nervous," a Sailor muttered beside him. "Are they afraid we will go ashore and start pillaging? I thought the

Guard Corps of the Sea Jewel, Pland, would be a bit stronger than the useless lot up in Frost Sea."

Aiden did not even turn his head. He said: "If they did not come out to keep order, you would complain that Pland's Guard Corps did not even have the courage to go out and block the streets. If they really sent you to fight their Steam Tanks, would you go?"

"…I would not go. I do not want to be carried back onto the deck in a bucket again," the Sailor hurriedly shook his head, then looked toward the direction where the Steam Walkers had just left. "The captain went off with them… He will be all right, yes? That tall young woman looks hard to mess with. I do not think the captain could beat her…"

"We did not come here to fight. We came here by invitation. Invitation, understand?" Aiden finally could not help giving the Sailor a sidelong look. "You – and the rest of you – can you adjust your mindset a little? Have you forgotten the captain's usual lectures? We are now the Sea Mist Venture Company. Raiding does not last. Doing business makes money faster than robbery, does it not?"

"Then when do we go raiding?"

Aiden thought for a moment, a ray of sunlight glinting off his polished bald head. "Naturally, when the other side refuses to do business…"

Several Undying Sailors nodded one after another, acknowledging the First Mate's wisdom. They fell quiet for only a few seconds before one Sailor, whose whole left skull had caved in, could not help glancing toward the city-state and mumbling: "Can we go ashore and have a look? Pland… I have heard that in this city…"

"Do not even think about it," Aiden cut him off at once. "The captain ordered that no one is to leave the Sea Mist without permission. You lot of

misfits would scare people to death if you went ashore. Pland is not the north. Hardly anyone here has seen a talking corpse."

"So the captain only picked the ones who look the most alive to go ashore, right?" the Sailor with the caved-in skull said resentfully, lifting a hand to support his head. "I think I look all right, actually. If I just covered this part with half a shell and put on a hat…"

"Shut it. Without the captain's orders, no one sets foot on land!" Aiden shot the chatterbox Sailor a fierce glare. "If you truly have nothing to do, go below and see whether those poor bastards who were plastered to the deck earlier have come back to life. If they have, tell them to report in…"

A faint clicking sound suddenly came from not far away, cutting off Aiden's orders.

Everyone on the bridge heard the faint clicking. Several gazes turned at once toward the source of the sound, and the Sailor who had spoken first spotted where it came from.

Beside the captain's seat stood a strange machine made of a mass of gears, connecting rods, and spirit compass needles. The machine now sat quietly, but several of its needles still trembled slightly, as if showing that a moment ago it had suddenly moved.

"Did this thing just move?" A Sailor standing closest walked carefully over to the delicate, complex machine, staring at the spirit compass needles that had already gone still.

Aiden walked over as well. His gaze fell on the hemispherical little bowl at the center of the machine. A bit of dried blood remained there, a trace left from the last time Captain Tyrian had used this device.

The bald First Mate's brow furrowed bit by bit.

As the captain’s most trusted subordinate, Aiden knew this device very well.

Anomaly 203, the Blood-Seeking spirit compass, was a brass machine of complex structure and unknown principles. It had once been part of the Queen of Frostholm’s collection. Now it belonged to Captain Tyrian.

Among the ranked Anomalies, this machine counted as one of the more “positive” types. Blood could be poured into the small central bowl, and after absorbing the fresh blood it used a series of spirit compasses to indicate the location of the user’s blood relatives. The priority of its indications was linked to the closeness of the blood relation, the physical distance, and the user’s own intent.

Compared with most Anomalies that carried direct malice and could become lethal merely through improper storage, the Blood-Seeking spirit compass was relatively safe to keep. It did not require any special sealing conditions. But once activated, the device revealed a far more sinister side.

First, once blood had been poured into it, the user would be constantly tempted by the spirit compass, developing an urge to keep feeding it blood. Those of weak mind might even bleed themselves to death in the process. Second, though the Blood-Seeking spirit compass could indeed help the user find their blood kin, it often “smuggled in misfortune” during that process, guiding events toward worse and worse outcomes as the user and their relatives drew closer.

In the cases Aiden knew alone, Anomaly 203 had once guided a father to the son he had lost for many years, only for the two of them to somehow kill each other by mistake the moment they met.

Yet these negative effects had never mattered much to Captain Tyrian. His will was strong enough to resist the Blood-Seeking spirit compass’s “call to offer blood”. As for the misfortune that came when blood kin drew near…

To begin with, the captain and Miss Lucretia would never meet while Anomaly 203 was active. Second, the Abnomar father and son had always been “a loving father and a filial son”.

Even the Blood-Seeking spirit compass could not produce a “reunion” more Plague dusk than two curse warships meeting and immediately blanketing each other with fire.

For the past half century, Captain Tyrian had often used the Blood-Seeking spirit compass as a kind of “warning device”, using it to determine whether the Vanished had returned to the Mortal Realm.

Aiden and the Sailors gathered around Anomaly 203. Several pairs of eyes were fixed on the ancient spirit compasses around the brass device, each one decorated with complicated patterns.

Its gears and needles had fallen completely still.

“…Maybe it just wanted to stretch a little,” a Sailor with a hole in his forehead said cautiously, as if trying to ease the tension. “After all, this thing is usually completely motionless…”

Aiden glared at the Sailor. “If you cannot make a decent joke, then do not make one.”

“Or… should we wipe away the blood in the middle?” another Sailor, shriveled like a mummified corpse, spoke up. “Otherwise I keep feeling as if this thing is about to wake up at any moment.”

“No,” Aiden shook his head. “The captain gave strict orders. The blood in the center of the spirit compass cannot be wiped off by hand. We have to wait seventy-two hours and let the spirit compass absorb it on its own.”

“…What happens if we wipe it early?”

“No one knows. It is hard enough to work out the correct way to use an Anomaly. Who would be full and bored enough to test all the wrong operations?” Aiden said casually. “Unless you want to try. We will count it as a contribution to Human civilization.”

“No, no, no, I was just saying.”

Aiden snorted coldly.

Click, click.

At that moment, the Blood-Seeking spirit compass suddenly made that faint mechanical sound again. The conversation between the First Mate and the Sailors broke off at once. Aiden immediately looked toward the machine and saw its gears begin to quiver. Several spirit compass needles around its edge jerked violently, and then all of the needles suddenly pointed toward the waters around Pland.

The Blood-Seeking spirit compass fell silent once more, and this time it seemed truly unlikely to move again.

All of its needles were now avoiding Pland itself.

Aiden and the Sailors looked at one another.

“…I told you it just wanted to stretch a little…”

“Be quiet.” Aiden cut the Sailor off, but his eyes stayed fixed on Anomaly 203 as he replayed what he had just seen in his mind.

All the needles had turned to random directions outside Pland, yet he was certain that in one brief instant the Blood-Seeking spirit compass’s needles had all pointed in the same direction, toward the city-state of Pland itself.

That moment had been extremely short, so short that anyone might suspect it was just a coincidence during the needles’ aimless spinning. But to Aiden,

it was as if the spirit compasses' many "eyes" had just caught sight of their target and then, in terror, jerked their gaze away.

And now, with all of Anomaly 203's needles pointing only to the waters near Pland, the situation looked to Aiden more like a clumsy attempt at covering something up.

He suddenly remembered something the captain had once told him.

Anomaly 203 sometimes behaved like a living thing. It did not always run in a purely mechanical way.

This thing could feel fear.

"Something is wrong… There is a problem with this city-state!" Aiden realized all at once. "We have to tell the captain what is happening here."

"But did the captain not order that we are forbidden to go ashore?"

"We will send a message first," Aiden said quickly, looking toward one of the Sailors. "Go, bring Polly here!"

The Sailor ran off at once. Not long after, he ran back to the bridge. A huge parrot with mottled tail feathers perched on his shoulder, rubbing its beak against the back of the Sailor's exposed skull.

"Polly, we need you to carry a message," Aiden called loudly.

The parrot immediately stopped tormenting the Sailor, lifted its head, and stared at the First Mate: "Polly can carry a message."

"Go to the great Cathedral of the city-state. Look for the captain's aura and tell him this: the Blood-Seeking spirit compass pointed to Pland. The city-state is not safe."

Chapter 230: Cozy Daily Life in the Subspace Nest

The large parrot with its brilliantly colored tail feathers beat its wings as it left the Sea Mist, streaking over the docks at surprising speed and flying straight toward the city-state.

“First Mate, what do we do? Are we just waiting here?”

On the bridge of the Sea Mist, a sailor watched Polly’s distant figure, then turned to the silent Aiden and asked.

“…We can only wait for now.” Aiden lowered his head and glanced at the deck under his feet. He weighed things quickly, forcing his cold mind to run as fast as it could. “Not only because of the captain’s order, but also because of the Sea Mist’s current condition.”

That second half of his words quickly calmed the few men who had still been a little restless.

The captain had gone ashore with only a few trusted aides, leaving his First Mate and all the other sailors on the ship. The official reason was that most of the Sea Mist’s Undying sailors looked strange and frightening, which could easily cause unrest and hostility inside the city-state. But Aiden knew the real reason very well.

Because not long ago, the Sea Mist had just run into its own flagship.

The ship was in bad shape now, not only because its hull was damaged, but because the ship’s “soul” was restless. The Sea Mist’s boiler kept

shuddering, strange hollow sounds echoed through the small Cathedral, and the pressure in the steam pipes still had not fully stabilized. The ship had indeed returned to “this side”, but it was hard to say whether it would fall into a runaway state again.

When the ship was unstable like this, the sailors who had served on her for over half a century were its “anchors”. The Sea Mist’s iron anchor let her rest on the sea’s surface, while the Undying formed an Anchor of Humanity that kept her steady in the dimension of the Mortal Realm.

Aiden did not dare reduce the number of sailors on board. After vaguely sensing how strange Pland’s situation was, he dared even less to let the Sea Mist’s crew wander into the city-state at will. That could easily cause a “jolt” and wake the ship’s barely calmed “soul”.

Likewise, he did not dare let the Sea Mist signal the city-state of Pland directly, whether by whistle, bell, or a telegraph to the city’s authority. He feared he might alarm some power hidden inside Pland.

Sending the parrot Polly with a message was the lowest risk plan he could think of. He only hoped that once the captain got the news, he would hurry back, that nothing had trapped him yet, and that it was not too late.

Of course, he also could not put all his hopes on “waiting”. If the captain still had not returned after a day, he would have to send a small part of the crew ashore to take the risk.

Aiden frowned tightly and cast his gaze toward the pearl-like city shining under the sunlight. He replayed every detail of the captain leaving with that city Inquisitor, trying to find anything wrong that could explain Anomaly 203’s abnormal behavior just now.

…

Duncan, who was sitting by the counter turning the pages of a newspaper, suddenly stopped and looked thoughtfully toward the window.

Alice, who sat next to him pretending to flip through a paper as well, noticed and asked curiously: “Mr. Duncan, what are you looking at?”

“…I suddenly felt like something glanced this way,” Duncan muttered with a frown, unsure. “But it vanished the moment I blinked.”

“Oh oh, I know. That’s called a ‘Champion’s Shiver’! Mr. Goathead told me about it,” Alice said happily. “He said the stronger you are, the easier it is to feel gazes or even thoughts aimed at you, and someone as strong as you will be getting shivers all the time…”

Duncan set the paper down and looked at Alice with no expression: “He really said that?”

Alice’s smile froze a little. “…I figured out the last part myself.”

“Don’t waste time on that kind of useless reasoning.” Duncan said it casually, then focused a little and started looking for the source of that sudden shiver.

He did not treat that fleeting feeling as a hallucination. After living so long in a world full of the uncanny, he had formed the habit of paying attention to every sudden intuition and digging to the bottom of it.

Duncan’s senses spread quickly, reaching toward the city’s edges. In a moment, Pland appeared in his mind with clear outlines, just like the Vanished did. Just as he could feel the Vanished’s “texture”, he began to feel the complex “touch” this city under his feet sent to him. Among all those sensations, one message stood out, the sharpest and most abrupt.

In the southeastern Harbor of Pland.

“…Tyrian’s ship?” Duncan was a bit surprised when he sensed the source of that aura. “Why is he here?”

Then he recalled his earlier clash with that ironclad warship, the position it had been in back then and the intent it showed in battle. After a brief moment of thought, his expression grew a bit odd.

The Sea Mist had appeared near Pland and taken the initiative to attack the Vanished… Was it actually “reinforcements” that Pland’s authority had called in, meant to intercept him?

Duncan vaguely guessed the cause and effect in his mind, but only felt both amused and annoyed. He did not know whether to sigh first over this “loving father and filial son” relationship, or over Tyrian’s dedication as reinforcements. After being beaten by the Vanished until his ship almost sank, the man had still stubbornly made it to Pland. What kind of spirit was that?

It definitely was not a spirit of “duty bound to protect world peace”.

Most likely, it was the spirit of “nothing is more fun than fighting with your own dad”.

“Mr. Duncan, you’re spacing out again,” Alice’s voice sounded at his side once more. The doll tilted her head slightly as she looked at him. “Do you want to go out?”

“No.” Duncan shook his head while keeping his senses on the Sea Mist. Because that ship had not yet become one of his “collections” like the Vanished and Pland, he could not sense its details. But thinking of his “connection” with the Sea Mist and with Tyrian, he had already started searching for the position of his “eldest son”. There was no point explaining such complicated things to Alice, who would not understand anyway, so he

did not bother. He only frowned when he saw the doll tilt her head. “Don’t tilt your head. It will fall off.”

Alice quickly nodded in small jerks. “Oh, oh.”

Just then, footsteps sounded behind the small door behind the counter. The door opened, and a small figure slipped out.

“Mr. Duncan.” Shirley patted the dust off her skirt and greeted Duncan with a proud look. “The storeroom is all cleaned up! All that junk you told me about has been piled onto one shelf!”

“Mm, nicely done.” Duncan kept part of his attention on the Harbor while he turned and nodded to Shirley. “You still have some dust on your shoulder.”

“Oh.” Shirley turned and brushed the dust away, then looked at Duncan a little nervously. “Mr. Duncan, what… do we do next?”

When she spoke with Duncan here, her expression was clearly not as terrified as it had been on the Vanished. She was still obviously tense, and that tension would not go away in a short time. But compared with the beginning, she was clearly much better now.

Clearly, at least in her mind she knew Duncan meant her well. As for that lingering tension, they would have to fix Dog’s nerves first.

Duncan nodded, then let his gaze slide over to Alice, who was still messing randomly with the newspaper even though she could not read a single word.

Illiterate.

Then he looked at Shirley across from him.

Another illiterate.

And there was Dog, hiding in the nearby Shadows, not showing himself but unable to hide his presence.

Also illiterate.

He had brought this trio in to help at the shop, and not one of them could even keep the books.

Duncan sighed inwardly, then remembered an earlier idea and his old line of work.

“Come on, you all sit here. Shirley, sit on Alice’s right,” Duncan said as he dragged a chair over to the counter. “Dog, squat behind the counter… stop hiding, I see your shadow. All of you come here. I have a plan.”

Shirley quickly obeyed and sat down. Alice finally put down the newspaper she could not read and looked over curiously: “Ah, what plan?”

“Nina is still out buying things. We have nothing better to do, so I’ll teach you to read,” Duncan said cheerfully, standing up and straightening his clothes. “You can’t stay illiterate forever.”

Shirley had never expected Captain Duncan’s serious “plan” to be this, and she froze on the spot. Alice, on the other hand, was full of curiosity; even her eyes seemed to light up. Dog, who had been crouching dutifully behind the counter, lifted his head to look at Duncan, then at Shirley, his dog head full of question marks: “But I’m just a dog…”

Duncan lowered his head at the words, but before he could say anything, the Abyssal Demon suddenly shuddered. Its whole upper body straightened. “But I can try to be a dog with culture. I have the passion and confidence…”

“Then that’s fine,” Duncan said in a pleased tone. He kept his attention on the Harbor while he reached under the counter and pulled out a few blank

notebooks, handing them out to his “students”. “These will be your letter books. We’ll start from the most basic letters…”

Shirley took the notebook from Duncan with a dazed look.

Then she became even more lost.

Letters and spelling were a door to a completely incomprehensible New World.

After only a few minutes, Shirley confirmed one thing: swinging Dog around and fighting cultists was easier than this!

But Duncan clearly did not care much about Shirley’s pained expression, or rather, he was long used to that kind of look.

He only felt joy, the joy of a wanderer in a foreign land suddenly touching something familiar and doing something he was used to.

But the happy time did not last long. When Shirley was stumbling over writing the fourth letter, a clear bell and light footsteps suddenly sounded at the door, cutting off this little “Subspace Shadows passing on knowledge to the retainers” class.

Nina’s cheerful voice came from the doorway: “Uncle Duncan! I’m back!”

Duncan lifted his head from the pleasant lesson and saw Nina pushing the door open. Then he noticed that something else was flying in behind her.

“I saw AI on the way back,” Nina said happily. “AI seems to have brought a friend!”

“A friend?”

Duncan frowned slightly, then saw AI flying into the shop behind Nina. Right after the pigeon came a large parrot with brilliant tail feathers…

Duncan: “…?”

Chapter 231: Reliable Messenger Polly

AI flapped into the shop, landed proudly on the stair railing, puffed out his chest, and let his little beady eyes dart around.

The large parrot with the colorful tail feathers flew in right after him and landed on the counter by Duncan's hand. It strutted along the counter, head held high, as if it were at home.

Duncan stared in disbelief at this stranger that had flown in from who knew where. The big parrot lifted its head and looked right back at him without the least bit of shyness. After a long moment, it suddenly flapped its wings and let out a loud, sharp cry: "Ah! Polly!"

"Your name is Polly?" Duncan asked curiously. He did not expect a real answer. Parrots only repeated things, after all. But to his surprise, the bird actually nodded at his question and flapped its wings. "Polly! Name is Polly!"

Duncan's expression went blank for a moment. Then he turned to AI, who was still standing on the railing and looking down proudly at the first floor. "Where did you find this… 'friend'?"

"A friend came from afar," AI said at once, flapping his wings. One eye looked at Duncan, while the other drifted toward the window. "Since he's here, let him stay!"

Nina asked curiously from the side: "What does he mean?"

After learning the secret of the Vanished and Duncan, Nina had of course also learned that AI could talk. She had been very shocked at first, but now she had calmed down. Still, just like everyone else, she had a hard time understanding the strange lines the pigeon came out with from time to time.

“He probably means he doesn’t know where the parrot came from either,” Duncan translated for AI with some imagination. Then he turned to look at the parrot, then the pigeon. After holding it in for a long while, he finally could not help himself. “AI… I don’t mind you making friends, but have you noticed you’re not even the same species? At least find yourself a pigeon…”

“The sea holds all rivers, true greatness comes from tolerance,” the Pigeon Spirit cried, tilting his head and staring straight ahead. “Tolerance!”

Duncan: “…”

He often found himself pondering life and doubting his own sanity when talking with AI, wondering whether he and this bird spirit were even on the same channel.

This feeling, that nothing matched up yet somehow they could still communicate, was really something.

At this point, Shirley, Dog, and Alice were all drawn over. The three of them crowded around the counter, staring at the fearless big parrot. Alice even reached out and poked its wing in curiosity. The parrot only hopped aside twice to dodge a little, then tilted its head and stared back at the doll, big eyes and small eyes glaring at each other.

“What is this?” Alice looked at Duncan curiously. “It looks completely different from AI.”

Shirley answered right away: “Of course it’s different. This is a parrot. AI is a pigeon.”

“What’s a parrot?” Alice asked the question from her soul. “Can you eat it?”

“No.” Shirley shook her head, then asked the doll in turn, “You don’t even need to eat. Why are you always asking that?”

“I’m in charge of cooking for the ship… for Mr. Duncan!”

The chatter around the counter rose in a jumble, but Duncan did not join in. He only looked thoughtfully at the big parrot that called itself Polly. For some reason, he felt the bird looked faintly familiar, as if he had seen it somewhere not long ago.

“Where did you come from? Why did you come here?” he asked suddenly.

During the earlier exchange, he had already sensed that this parrot could actually communicate with people to some extent. Clearly, it did not have an ordinary origin.

The big parrot turned its head and tilted it. “Polly! Go, send message!”

“Send a message?” Duncan froze for a second, and his expression grew a bit more serious. “What message?”

The big parrot tilted its head as if thinking. After rummaging through its memories, it opened its beak, but before it could say anything, AI suddenly flapped over and yelled at the top of his lungs: “Get some fries!”

The big parrot jumped in fright. “Ah! Polly!”

“Get some fries!” The pigeon landed in front of the parrot and nodded with a very serious face. “Get some fries.”

“Polly?” “Get some fries!”

The two birds went on talking like that, until Duncan had to cut in: “Stop. AI, shut up. Polly, what message are you sending, and to whom?”

The big parrot clearly froze. After several seconds, it rocked its body back and forth hesitantly. “Get some fries.”

Duncan: “…”

He suddenly realized something. Whatever message this parrot had been supposed to deliver, it had obviously forgotten it completely…

But then Polly seemed to dig some useful scraps out of its remaining memory. It suddenly hopped up and flapped its wings hard: “Tell the captain, tell the captain! Tell… get some fries!”

Right after that, the big parrot flapped its wings and flew straight toward the door, still shouting “Get some fries!” Before anyone could react, it had already rushed out the door, into the sky, and was speeding toward Pland’s Upper City.

Nina tried to stop the parrot, but she was too late. She could only watch its figure fly farther and farther away with a regretful face, then turn back muttering: “Ah, it flew off.”

Duncan did not answer. When he heard Polly shout the words “tell the captain”, his expression had suddenly turned serious. At the same time, he remembered why the parrot had seemed faintly familiar.

He had indeed seen this bird before, when the Vanished and the Sea Mist overlapped in passing, in one of the Sea Mist’s cabins.

“AI, chase that parrot.”

…

“That is roughly the situation.”

In a quiet reception room somewhere in Pland’s great Cathedral, the old Bishop Valentine, dressed in plain clothes, spoke to Tyrian, who sat on the sofa across the coffee table.

“In the end, the Vanished took away the fragment of the Sun, stopped the creeping Sun Wheel from descending, and wiped out the effects of the historical corruption on the city-state, though we still cannot be sure of your father’s intent…”

Tyrian’s expression was both subtle and stiff.

He could no longer remember how many years it had been since shock had left his thoughts stuck like this. He understood every word the old Bishop said, but even in his wildest and strangest dreams, he had never imagined something like this could happen.

“The Vanished really just left like that? It looked like it came here just to save the day?” The famous pirate captain sounded full of disbelief. “It took the fragment of the Sun… and then? That was it? It didn’t do anything else?”

Valentine and Vanna exchanged a look. Both their faces held a mix of helplessness and hesitation.

At this point, it was really hard to say the words “your dad robbed half the city’s fries” to Tyrian’s face.

“…Nothing else,” the old Bishop said at last after much hesitation. He still could not bring himself to say it. He shook his head and sighed. “I know you are confused, Mr. Tyrian. We are as confused as you are. If even you don’t know what your father wants, then we know even less.”

“He stopped counting as my father a century ago,” Tyrian said slowly, shaking his head with a deep voice. “He is only a copy, torn apart by Subspace and then clumsily stitched back together. There is no trace of humanity in that empty shell…”

Tyrian suddenly stopped. For some reason, he recalled those few seconds when the Vanished and the Sea Mist overlapped, and the cold, distant words

he had heard then.

“I’m busy.”

The Pirate Lord felt a sudden hesitation.

Was there really no humanity inside that body on the Vanished? The voice that had spoken to him back then, and the aura he had felt from that figure… were those really just the hollow, mad echoes of Subspace?

As Tyrian drifted off in thought, the young Inquisitor’s voice suddenly came from the other side, breaking his wandering thoughts: “Whether Captain Duncan still has ‘humanity’ is exactly what we are going to discuss next.”

“Hm?” Tyrian looked at Vanna in confusion. “What do you mean?”

“In fact…” Vanna hesitated, then turned to exchange a glance with Bishop Valentine before nodding lightly. “We have had more than one exchange with your father recently.”

Matters related to the Vanished were classified, and speaking with Captain Duncan was even more so. None of this should have been revealed. But Tyrian’s identity was so special that these rules clearly no longer applied.

“Exchanges? With my father?!” Tyrian was indeed shocked and almost jumped up from the sofa. “Is this some kind of bad joke?”

“Please calm down. This is a very serious matter, no one would joke about something like this after the city-state almost fell,” Vanna said calmly, looking at Tyrian before pausing slightly. “Strictly speaking, I am the one who has had several exchanges with your father. And from what I observed, ‘Captain Duncan’ no longer matches the description in the records.”

Tyrian sensed how serious she was and quickly calmed down. His own expression grew especially grave. “Miss Inquisitor, how did you establish

contact? Why did he seek you out? And… what did he say?”

“At first, it was an accident… no, thinking about it now, it may have been a deliberate arrangement by your father,” Vanna said as she gathered her thoughts and recalled. “I came into contact with the ‘flame’ he left behind and used it to establish the connection. As for why he chose me… sadly, no one knows…”

Vanna left out the details about the mark placed on her and the corruption that could not be cleansed, summarizing it vaguely as “establishing contact”. Then she told the pirate captain in front of her the details of her talks with Captain Duncan.

The man who, in theory, knew Duncan Abnomar best.

Chapter 232: Tyrian’s Memories

After listening to Vanna’s account, Tyrian fell silent for a short while.

Without seeing it with his own eyes, he still could not work out from these few words what plans that Ghost who had returned from Subspace now had, or how he had gone through such changes. But one thing was certain – the “Captain Duncan” Vanna described was definitely not the mad Monster the Sea Mist had encountered on the Frost Sea half a century ago.

Nor did he much resemble the great explorer, the Father from a century ago that Tyrian remembered.

“Captain Tyrian,” after the reception room had been quiet for a long time, Vanna finally spoke, breaking Tyrian’s thoughts. “What do you think?”

“I… can hardly believe this really happened, but since it has, we have to accept it for now,” Tyrian said, his brow slowly furrowing as he thought. “From what you described, he did seem to be clear-headed, sane, and still human. But his power… that curse-like flame… it has become stronger as well.”

Vanna nodded: “I don’t know if that emerald flame was the curse or not, but it was indeed very powerful.”

“That flame was connected to Subspace,” Tyrian said. “He gained that strange power after he fell into Subspace, so calling it the curse is not wrong.”

“…So if that flame is even stronger than what you saw half a century ago, that means Captain Duncan’s connection to Subspace has grown deeper than before,” the old Bishop Valentine mused. “So he has not broken free of Subspace’s influence, but sunk into it even further – yet at the same time, he somehow recovered?”

“…That didn’t fit what we knew about Subspace.” Tyrian shook his head.

“Followers of Rahm often say one thing,” Valentine said. “The only thing we know about Subspace is that we never know enough about it. For thousands of years, aside from the Vanished, nothing from the Mortal Realm has ever entered Subspace and then returned to this world. And apart from a few indirect observations and the mad scribblings left by the insane scholars of the ancient kingdom of Critt, no one knows what truly exists inside Subspace… Any ‘laws’ we think we have summed up about that place are in fact meaningless.”

At this point, the learned old man paused and sighed slowly: “We cannot even be sure that Subspace is actually a ‘place’ at all –

“Sixteen hundred years ago, the mad scholar Belmin was devoured by something invisible in front of a crowd after reading an ancient scroll. Before he vanished, he shouted, ‘Subspace is the shadow on the back of the world.’ That one sentence drove one hundred and forty-two witnesses insane. Yet, taking the madness of those one hundred and forty-two people as sacrificial victims, that single piece of information became the greatest step we have taken in millennia toward understanding Subspace.

“Even now, scholars are still trying to build a theoretical model of Subspace from Belmin’s last cry… And your Father not only actually went into that place, he even came back to our world with his mind intact.”

“Yes. Year after year they study, and year after year people die. The dead are quickly replaced, and the studying continues… So I actually had a lot of

respect for those death-defying scholars of the Truth Academy – purely in a good way," Tyrian sighed and shook his head, then his voice grew a little lower. "So now my 'Father' may have become a valuable specimen? A specimen that truly went into Subspace, and can still be reasoned with?"

"That's only wishful thinking," Valentine spread his hands. "We cannot expect 'Captain Duncan' to cooperate with mortal research. And even though he is rational now, we cannot rashly assume that his reason is still on the side of humans. If he is a lucid Intruder from Subspace, that would be far more terrifying than those mindless chaotic projections."

For a moment Tyrian said nothing, as if he had fallen into deep memories and thought. After an unknown time, he suddenly spoke: "Before his last expedition, there was a period when he seemed anxious and unsettled… No, to be precise, it felt as if he had been anxious about something for a long time, and had been making many… chilling preparations for it."

Valentine immediately exchanged a look with Vanna, and both of their faces grew serious.

This might have been the first time in a century that anyone had heard these crucial secrets from the mouth of Captain Duncan's descendant!

Vanna could not help asking: "What was he anxious about? What was he preparing for?"

"The world's Doomsday." Tyrian raised his head and spoke calmly.

Valentine frowned slightly: "Doomsday?"

"I know it sounds a bit cliché, like the crazy talk of those doomsday prophets who pop up every year. But this really was the thing that kept the greatest explorer in the world a hundred years ago awake day and night."

Tyrian let out a soft sigh and went on.

“From the day Lucretia and I took over command of the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star, he would bring it up from time to time.

“He seemed to think our world had some kind of… countdown, or some limit of time. On the surface, the mortal world looked calm and peaceful, but he believed that countdown was already close to the End. Once the time came, everything would quickly fall into collapse and termination, and no one would be able to change or stop it. And he believed… our era was the last tick of that countdown.”

Valentine frowned: “To be honest, I don’t think our world counts as ‘calm’…”

“But in my Father’s words, he called the present mortal world ‘the last pastoral age’.”

Vanna thought for a moment and asked: “So he fell into Subspace while trying to find a way to stop this ‘countdown’?”

“No. He wanted to search for Anomaly 000 – he believed Anomaly 000 could end the world’s distortion and jam that countdown. For that purpose, he passed through the ‘Eternal Veil’ at the end of the world.”

Valentine was startled: “He passed through the Eternal Veil?!”

“Yes… But I could only confirm that he did enter that fog. I don’t know if he truly managed to ‘pierce through’ it,” Tyrian said. “Back then he refused the escort of all the guard ships. All I knew for sure was that he came back from there alive – already tainted with madness. As for falling into Subspace… that happened afterward.”

Valentine and Vanna fell silent at the same time. After a while, Vanna took the initiative to break the silence: “Then did he find that so-called Anomaly 000? You know, in theory…”

“In theory there is no Anomaly or Vision numbered zero, I know. And he did come back with nothing,” Tyrian said calmly. “So I have always thought that when he decided to search for Anomaly 000, he was already not quite sane.”

Vanna thought for a moment and asked: “Then do you know why your Father first came to believe the world had a ‘countdown’? When did he get that idea? Did he come into contact with something, or… discover something?”

Tyrian thought carefully for a while, then said, a little unsure: “I… am not very certain. It was too long ago. But I vaguely remember that he once received a few people aboard the Vanished and talked with them all night. The first time he mentioned the world’s Doomsday to us was after that day.”

“He received a few people?” Valentine immediately grew serious. “What kind of people were they? What was the situation then?”

“They all wore coarse gray-white robes and were barefoot. As I remember… they were very thin, the kind of thinness that looks like the result of long ascetic practice, as if they had gone through a very long journey. They appeared on the Vanished during its voyage, as if they had already arranged with Father to come aboard as guests,” Tyrian said slowly. “After they talked all night, Father said the guests had left. But I never saw them leave the ship. It was as if they vanished into thin air.”

Valentine’s expression turned a bit odd: “Enders? That sounds very much like…”

“Your Excellency Bishop, do you think that after living a hundred years I wouldn’t recognize a Ender?” Tyrian shook his head lightly. “I suspected the same thing, but those people were definitely not the Enders we know.

They were rational and friendly, and there was no trace of madness on them."

"Rational and friendly?" Valentine blinked and said thoughtfully, "I have indeed never heard of any rational Ender… Did those people have any other traits?"

This time Tyrian thought back for much longer. After several minutes he suddenly raised his head: "One of them spoke a few words to me. I don't clearly remember exactly what, just ordinary greetings. But I remember they called themselves 'humble seekers of the Way', and also…"

Tyrian paused and looked around: "Do you have a pen?"

"Yes." Vanna quickly took some paper and a pen from the side. "Here."

Tyrian took them, lowered his head, and drew a pattern on the coffee table. Valentine and Vanna both leaned over curiously.

They saw a hexagonal emblem. At its center was a broken, cross-shaped pattern. When Tyrian drew that cross, his lines clearly hesitated, as if his memory of it had already grown blurry.

"It was roughly like this. One of them wore a charm amulet with this emblem on it. That charm amulet seemed very important. He would not let me touch it, only said it was their guidance and protection on the path they sought."

Vanna frowned and studied the pattern for a long time, then looked back at Valentine: "You have seen more things. Do you recognize this?"

"…Never," Valentine also studied it for a long time, then shook his head hesitantly. "It doesn't look like any known religious symbol, nor like anything the classical city-states used."

"Is that so…"

Vanna muttered softly, her eyes still fixed on the sheet of paper.

The strange pattern on the paper was reflected in her eyes.

Reflected there along with it was also a tiny cluster of faint, ghostly green flame, almost impossible to see with the naked eye.

Chapter 233: The Family curse

Bishop Valentine put away the sheet that showed the strange emblem.

“None of us recognize this pattern. It is likely from a very ancient era, or from a secret society that has never exposed itself,” the old Bishop said as he folded the paper away. “We might find some record of it in the archives. I’ll also contact some friends in the academic world and see if any of them know it.”

Vanna’s gaze returned to Tyrian. She looked curiously at the pirate captain before her: “Before your Father had that secret talk with those strange ‘ascetics’, was there anything else unusual about him? For example, did he suddenly obtain some mysterious book, or explore some hidden ruin?”

“That’s hard to say,” Tyrian shook his head. “You should know that a century ago, he was one of the greatest explorers in this world. Dealing with all kinds of strange relics and secret places was his daily work. He spent almost all his time with the very things you just mentioned, and back then Lucretia and I had only just started helping Father with a few matters. We had very little chance to learn in detail about his ‘collection’. And besides…”

Tyrian paused here and let out a soft sigh.

“Back then Lucretia and I had no idea what would happen later. Those strange ‘Visitors’ were odd, but Father often received all kinds of strange guests. By the time we noticed that his state was getting worse and worse,

almost a year had passed since that ‘private talk’. It was impossible to go back and investigate anything then.”

Vanna nodded lightly. Just then, a loud bell and the blare of steam whistles suddenly came from outside the window, cutting off the conversation in the reception room.

“The dusk Bell has rung,” Bishop Valentine looked up toward the window. He saw the Sun, bound by twin rings of runes, slowly sinking below the sea’s horizon. In the sky, the faint outline of the World’s Wound could just be seen. “Let’s stop here for today.”

Then he drew back his gaze and nodded to Tyrian: “If you don’t mind, you can rest in the Great Cathedral tonight. We have already prepared dinner and quiet guest rooms for you.”

“Then thank you,” Tyrian agreed gladly, then added, “I plan to stay in this city-state for a few more days. A hundred years ago I lived here for a short time, and I’m quite interested in how it has changed.”

“Of course,” Valentine smiled. “The Sea Mist is already a friend of Pland. We are always ready for our friends – stay here as long as you like.”

Vanna rose from the sofa and nodded to Tyrian: “I’ll take you to your rooms.”

With this special meeting over, Tyrian left the reception room with Vanna and joined several accompanying sailors who had been resting in a nearby room. Together they walked toward the depths of the Great Cathedral.

“I didn’t expect Your Excellency the Inquisitor to personally lead the way,” Tyrian said casually on the way to the guest rooms. “For a ‘pirate’, this is quite an honor.”

“Only a ‘pirate’?” Vanna glanced back with a faint smile. “Your identity is not that simple – son of Duncan, general of the Queen of Frostholm,

Commander of the Sea Mist Fleet. If all the pirates on the Boundless Sea were like you… then we would have no need for any city-state authority."

"…Being a 'pirate' is just a convenient identity. It makes it easy for me to cause trouble for certain people on the Frost Sea. And they like this identity too; it lets them issue more wanted notices so they can pretend they are still useful," Tyrian said lightly. "But all those titles you just mentioned are things of the past, Your Excellency Inquisitor."

After a brief silence, Tyrian went on: "I have never told an outsider this much about 'him'. I hope you understand that."

"Of course," Vanna nodded slightly. "If I were in your place, I also wouldn't want to reveal my family's… 'curse' to outsiders. Sorry, I can't think of a better word."

"It's all right. It really is a curse," Tyrian sighed. "If not for the strange and bizarre events in Pland, and for you bringing up his anomalous condition just now, there are some things I truly wouldn't want to remember."

As he spoke, his gaze unconsciously swept across Vanna's eyes. A second later, he lowered his eyes without meaning to.

That faint, elusive pressure appeared again, even more obvious than what he had felt at the docks.

Thinking of how this young Inquisitor had recently communicated with 'that person' several times, Tyrian even began to have some frightening guesses about that indescribable pressure.

Vanna noticed his odd behavior.

"You look a bit stiff, Captain Tyrian," she asked very directly. "Do I make you nervous?"

“No, Your Excellency Inquisitor,” Tyrian shook his head, then spoke a bit hesitantly. “I just suddenly thought of what you said earlier. You said you have spoken with my Father several times… Besides talking, did he ever give you anything else? For example, power?”

Vanna’s steps stopped suddenly.

“Why do you ask that?”

“I meant nothing else by it,” Tyrian suddenly realized that his question might sound offensive to a devout and steadfast Saint, and hurried to explain. “I just wanted to remind you, my Father… the power he brought back from Subspace is very strange and very hard to remove. Like other chaotic corruption from Subspace, that power is extremely corrupting. If you are contaminated too deeply by it…”

“Thank you for the warning.” Vanna took a deep breath and thanked him sincerely.

But in truth she thought his warning had come a little too late – Captain Duncan’s influence was far more serious than anyone imagined. Now she could only hope that the next time the captain came to her, he would at least knock on the door…

Tyrian had no idea what was going through the Inquisitor’s mind. He only felt that the air had grown rather awkward. But the awkwardness did not last long – Vanna was the first to break the silence.

“I’m curious about one thing,” she suddenly asked. “About that ‘countdown’ your Father mentioned before he went mad… Do you know anything more about it? Did he ever mention any other details?”

When she asked this, what rose in Vanna’s mind was the time she had communicated with Gamona, the storm Goddess, and the hard-to-understand words the Goddess had spoken to her –

Time is limited. The threshold is near.

Back then she had not understood that sentence at all. Now, hearing Tyrian talk about the ‘countdown’, it suddenly seemed deeply connected to it!

Tyrian met Vanna’s gaze.

After a few seconds of silence, he spoke in a low voice: “In his last days, he once suddenly said something to Lucretia. He said – ‘Our world is nothing but a pile of dying embers’.”

The corridor had reached its end.

“Thank you for leading the way,” Tyrian nodded to Vanna. “I’d like to spend some time with my subordinates now.”

Vanna snapped out of her thoughts. Tyrian’s last sentence still echoed in her heart. She nodded without thinking and took her leave of this Pirate Lord.

The door of the guest room closed. Only when everything around him grew quiet did Tyrian truly breathe out in relief.

He replayed his last conversation with the young Inquisitor, and that faint pressure he had felt from her. Only now did a belated sense of dread slowly spread through him.

In a daze, he remembered the last moment when his eyes had met the Inquisitor’s…

In that instant, he had actually felt as if he were standing under his Father’s gaze!

“Captain, are you all right?” A sailor who was also his trusted aide looked at his boss with some concern. “You’ve been on edge ever since you came ashore.”

“…I’m fine,” Tyrian pulled himself together and waved at his subordinates, then walked toward a nearby table. “Bring the things here.”

A sailor immediately stepped forward and put a carrying case from the Sea Mist onto the table. Tyrian used the key to open the box, revealing what was inside.

It was a complex lens array device, made of many small lenses and curved linkages. At its center sat a large scrying crystal.

“Watch the door. Don’t let anyone disturb me.” Tyrian ordered his subordinates.

After several sailors had left, he finally focused his attention on the scrying crystal. He gently adjusted the angle of one of the lenses and called softly: “Lucretia.”

After quite a while, the array of lenses began to tremble and turn. The scrying crystal at the center started to glow faintly. Amid the crackle of interference noise, Lucretia’s blurry figure appeared inside the crystal: “I’m here.”

“Why is it so blurry?” Tyrian frowned. “Where are you now?”

“I… am at the border…” Lucretia’s voice came from the scrying crystal, full of crackling interference but still barely understandable. “The environment… here… the interference has grown stronger. I’ll… adjust… Is it better now? Can you hear me clearly?”

The interference finally faded, and Lucretia’s figure slowly grew clearer.

“The environment here has changed a bit. The Spirit Realm is causing strange disturbances to the Mortal Realm,” the voice in the scrying crystal explained. “What is it, Brother? The Radiant Star is passing through an unstable sea area. If it’s nothing important…”

“I’m in Pland right now,” Tyrian got straight to the point. “The Sea Mist was badly damaged in a battle with the Vanished, and something seems very wrong with this city-state too.”

The figure on the other side of the scrying crystal froze.

A few seconds later, Lucretia’s slightly tense voice came through: “You really ran into the Vanished? Are you all right now?”

“…To be honest, I took quite a beating, but I’m all right for now,” Tyrian’s voice was low. “The problem is… something seems off with ‘him’.”

“Something is off with ‘him’?” Lucretia frowned. “You saw him up close?”

“Yes.”

“Then…” Lucretia opened her mouth, hesitating a little. “This time, the one you saw – was he our ‘Father’?”

“…Not entirely.”

Chapter 234: A Harmonious Family

Tyrian had to spend a lot of effort explaining to his younger sister the strange changes that had happened to Father, and the bizarre things Father had done in Pland.

“I can feel that he is no longer that frenzied, chaotic Subspace husk from half a century ago. There seems to be ‘humanity’ and ‘reason’ in that body now, but that feeling is also very strange to me… I don’t dare be sure what exactly is inside his shell,” Tyrian said slowly with a frown. “He still seems to recognize me, but aside from that bit of recognition, I have no idea how much of him is still the Father we knew. He… changed a great deal.”

The black-haired woman on the other side of the scrying crystal stayed silent for a few seconds, then said: “But it at least sounds better than how things were half a century ago.”

“…You could say that,” Tyrian said in a low voice. “Half a century ago, I stood on the bow of the Sea Mist, looking at that figure and wishing it was not him. Now, seeing him again, I am only confused about whether it really is him… In any case, the Vanished did not bring a great catastrophe this time like it used to.”

Lucretia did not respond. She only thought for a moment, then suddenly brought something up: “Do you remember what I told you last time? Lunie suddenly malfunctioned, then said that ‘Old Master’ was looking for me… Now it seems our Father really is planning something.”

“What would he plan?” Tyrian frowned. “To continue the last expedition he failed to finish back then? To gather the Vanished Fleet again?”

“I don’t know.”

Lucretia said this calmly.

At the same time, a patch of interfering shadows suddenly appeared again in the scrying crystal. Right after that, some of the automatically running magic devices behind Lucretia seemed to malfunction. Faint popping noises came from there, and a group of automata rushed up to check the equipment, looking thoroughly flustered.

“What’s going on over there?” Tyrian suddenly grew a little worried. “Do you need to deal with that pile of equipment behind you first?”

“Don’t worry. The automata will take care of it. It’s just a small problem, nothing worth mentioning compared to the real storms on the border,” Lucretia said calmly, not even glancing back at the chaotic scene. “I’m almost past this unstable sea area.”

“What are you exploring this time? You aren’t planning to rush straight into that fog, are you? Let me remind you, the border is not a safe place…”

“I’m tracking something. It suddenly appeared near the border and plunged into the sea with enormous energy, but the instruments on the ship didn’t have time to capture a clear image of it,” Lucretia still looked just as calm. “Don’t worry, it’s on the inner side of the Eternal Veil. I am not reckless enough to challenge that thick fog yet. Mm, once I find it, I’ll send you the recording. If it’s a material thing that can be cut up, I’ll slice off a piece as a souvenir for you.”

As soon as Tyrian heard that, he waved his hand: “No need. None of the souvenirs you send over are ever not cursed. I still want to sleep a few more nights in peace.”

Lucretia did not mind. She just followed up casually: “Then did you buy that Spirit Realm lens for me?”

Tyrian froze for a moment. His tone suddenly turned a bit unnatural: “That… might take a few more days. You know, you need luck to get that thing…”

“You forgot?”

“Of course not. The suppliers I know all ran out, and the four great Churches do have some, but the paperwork is too difficult…”

“You forgot, didn’t you?”

“I’m doing my best,” Tyrian said with a serious face. “There should be a solution other than robbery.”

“Then it seems you really did forget.” On the other side of the scrying crystal, Lucretia nodded to herself, her tone calm as though she had expected this. “It’s fine. You’re very busy, and it is a hard favor to ask…”

As Tyrian listened to his younger sister, you could see the relief appear on his face. Then he heard the rest of the sentence coming from the other side of the scrying crystal: “Then I’ll ask again the day after tomorrow.”

Tyrian: “…”

The pirate lord wiped his forehead and seemed about to say something, but just as he opened his mouth, the sound of wings flapping suddenly came from outside the window, cutting him off. A moment later came the tapping of a beak on glass.

“Hold on, something’s happening over here,” Tyrian said quickly as he looked up. A look of surprise came over his face. “Polly?!”

He hurriedly stood up and opened the window, letting in the big parrot with the brilliantly colored tail feathers. Polly flapped its wings as it landed on

the table with a flutter, shouting loudly: “Polly!”

Tyrian sat back down at the table, looking at the big parrot in confusion: “Why are you here? Did you sneak off the ship, or did Aiden send you?”

“Ah! Aiden sent Polly!” The big parrot spread its wings and bobbed its head up and down as it squawked: “Polly came to deliver a message, an important message! Aiden said… Aiden said…”

The parrot stalled, stuck for words. After quite a while, under Tyrian’s stunned divine gaze, it finally screeched: “Get some fries! Get some fries!”

Tyrian: “…?”

Lucretia on the other side of the scrying crystal also heard the commotion. Her puzzled voice came through: “Brother, is Polly hungry?”

“…No. It should be carrying some other message, but someone tampered with it.” Tyrian reacted at once. As Polly’s master, he knew this big parrot all too well, and he also knew Aiden’s personality just as well. His expression quickly turned serious. “Polly, did something happen on the ship?”

The big parrot tilted its head at its master and repeated “Get some fries” several more times, the meaning completely unclear. Then it suddenly stopped, as if it had finally remembered something. It cried out excitedly: “Blood-seeking spirit compass!”

Tyrian frowned slightly: “The Blood-seeking spirit compass?”

“It points at the city-state!” The big parrot beat its wings hard and yelled excitedly: “The Blood-seeking spirit compass, it points at the city-state!”

Tyrian suddenly froze, then reacted at once. His expression changed, and he snapped his head up to stare at the scrying crystal in front of him: “Lucy, he is…”

“Brother, leave Pland immediately.” Before Tyrian finished, Lucretia had already reacted on the other side of the scrying crystal. Her voice grew urgent as she said: “This could be a trap!”

But Tyrian did not respond at all to his younger sister’s urgent warning. He sat there rigid, like a frozen statue, eyes fixed straight ahead.

“Brother?” Lucretia’s voice now held confusion. “Didn’t you hear me?”

“Lucy, he is…” Tyrian finally broke the silence in a low voice. “…right across from me.”

The voice in the scrying crystal went quiet.

Tyrian stared fixedly ahead, at the other side of the table. On the wall over there, the surface of a decorative mirror with an oval frame was rippling with faint green flames. Amid the flickering fire, a stern figure stood in the mirror, calmly turning his divine gaze this way.

“First,” the figure in the mirror spoke. “This is not a trap. I am just as surprised that you came here.

“Second, I’m done with my work, so I came to see what you two are busy with.”

Tyrian still sat up straight, saying nothing. In the scrying crystal, Lucretia was just as stiff, but she could not see what was happening on the other side, and could only hear the voice. That made her even more uneasy, and she could not help whispering: “Is he really there?”

With no expression, Tyrian grabbed the box on the table and turned the scrying crystal and the lens assembly toward the other side: “Say hello to Father.”

As soon as Tyrian moved, Lucretia’s voice grew louder and more hurried: “No, no, no need to turn it, I just…”

She had already been turned.

Through the magic crystal sphere, she saw Father hanging on the wall.

Duncan also looked through the mirror surface at the woman inside the crystal sphere.

This was his first time seeing her, and in the mind of this body, aside from a faint impression of affection and nostalgia, he had no memory at all of being with her.

But that faint remaining sense of warmth and nostalgia still slowly spread through his heart. He had felt something similar when he saw Tyrian, but facing Lucretia now, that feeling seemed to carry a faint extra trace of… guilt and regret.

Was it because he owed her more? Or because of that last gift he never managed to send?

Duncan did not know. After all, those were not his own memories and feelings. It was only because of the identity he held now that he followed along, nodding to Lucretia: “Long time no see, Lucy.”

“Uh…” Lucretia’s expression grew unusually flustered and lost. This sea witch, who always presented herself as calm and mysterious, had finally run into something even harder to understand than the ever-changing border. She was so nervous and cramped that it felt as if she had gone back many, many years, back to that afternoon when she broke Father’s navigational instruments for the first time. “I… long time no see…”

After that, the room fell into an oppressive silence. Duncan only watched the pair of children in front of him in silence, his divine gaze on them. That wordless pressure seemed to pass through the scrying crystal all the way to the distant border of the Boundless Sea. Lucretia desperately searched her

mind for a topic to break this quiet, and after holding it in for a long time finally blurted out: “Your… your frame suits you quite well…”

Duncan: “…Hm?”

“I mean, this patterned frame you have now really matches your presence…” Lucretia tried to patch it up in a panic. “Restrained, understated, and…”

“…Huh?”

“Especially when you’re hanging on the wall…”

Even Duncan was stunned: “What exactly are you trying to say?”

Lucretia finally turned her head a little to the side, as if trying to find where Tyrian was, muttering under her breath: “Help me out…”

Tyrian sighed, pushed the carrying case that held the scrying crystal a little to the side, then stood up and stepped between the crystal sphere and the framed mirror: “You came to us. Is there something you need?”

Chapter 235: Across Time and Space

Across the illusory mirror surface and the flames, Duncan could still clearly observe Tyrian and Lucretia's reactions from beginning to end: tension, vigilance, and a faint trace of fear.

From the angle of a "family reunion", the atmosphere really did not qualify as good.

But he did not mind. He had expected this long ago. Being able to meet Tyrian in advance while the situation was still under his own control already fulfilled his goal for today. Meeting now to lay some groundwork might keep them from falling into a panicked mess the next time they suddenly ran into each other. All the more so when today even came with a "buy one, get one free".

He had not expected Lucretia to be there as well.

And just now, while he hid in the mirror, he had also listened to the exchange between Lucretia and Tyrian. He learned that his last attempt to contact Lucretia through Nilu had not been without effect. Even though he had not received a reply on his side, there had been a reaction on Lucretia's. That bit of information counted as an unexpected gain.

Steadying himself, Duncan kept his usual calm expression as his gaze slowly swept over Tyrian and the scrying crystal on the table beside him: "I thought a father did not need any special reason to look for his own children."

Tyrian’s eyes widened slightly for a moment, but he quickly forced that flicker of emotion down. He lowered his voice and still watched the man in the mirror warily: “You should know this is the Great Cathedral. Even you should at least show some regard for the deity behind this holy place.”

“Yes, this is the Great Cathedral. Of course I know.” Duncan’s tone stayed calm. “I watched it burn to ashes with my own eyes, then reshaped this place from shattered history. If the deity behind this Cathedral is watching, then that one actually owes me thanks.”

Tyrian instantly had no idea how to respond to that.

But this feeling of suddenly not knowing what to say in a conversation with Father was not unfamiliar to him.

Even a hundred years ago, when the Abnomar surname had not yet been entangled by the curse, he often fell silent in front of Father. Father had always been too imposing and obsessed with those mysterious and terrifying matters, while back then Tyrian had not been someone good with words.

And back then, whenever father and son fell into an awkward silence, it was always the livelier Lucretia who broke the deadlock.

“Your… your sanity has broken free from Subspace’s influence?” The voice of the sea witch came from the scrying crystal. Just like a hundred years ago, she broke the awkwardness between Father and her elder brother. “Did you come back this time to continue… your expedition plan?”

Duncan looked toward Lucretia. Under his calm exterior, his mind was racing.

This was a crucial meeting. In this meeting he had to lay a foundation for the future, to prepare cover and explanations in advance for the many doubts that might be exposed later. If possible, he wanted to make

everything that would change about the Vanished and himself from now on seem natural to these siblings.

Fortunately, he already had a draft prepared before he came.

“Subspace left an extremely deep mark on me. Perhaps for the rest of my life I will never be able to completely shake it off,” he began slowly, controlling his tone and expression. “There are many things I no longer remember clearly, including even my understanding of the Mortal Realm and… the way I perceive it. I am trying to get to know this world again, and after learning that you still exist, I believe you may be a key step in rebuilding that understanding.”

He paused here before going on: “But as you said, Lucy – at least, my sanity has returned.”

This was the most effective explanation he could think of to deal with hidden dangers and prepare for the future.

To keep the Vanished stable, he had to play the role of Captain Duncan well. Even after reaching a tacit understanding with Goathead, he could not abandon this identity. So he had to continue this performance in front of Lucretia and Tyrian. But no matter how skilled the performance, there would still be flaws, especially when he knew almost nothing about these two siblings. The most effective way, of course, was to prepare a scapegoat in advance.

And then put all the blame on Subspace.

After all, every weird thing in this world had something to do with Subspace. That place was practically the ultimate scapegoat, and it would not mind taking one more.

On top of that, he had deliberately stressed that what had gone wrong was not just his memory, but also his understanding and way of perceiving the

Mortal Realm. That was enough to explain almost everything odd about him.

The rest could be left to Tyrian and Lucretia's own imagination.

In the scrying crystal, Lucretia clearly froze for a moment after hearing Duncan's words. She seemed to be carefully studying Father's expression, trying to confirm whether what he said was true. Beside her, after a brief silence, Tyrian suddenly asked: "So your actions in Pland before were only to save this city-state?"

A smile appeared on Duncan's face: "Purely out of goodwill."

"…But the bishop and inquisitor in the city do not seem so ready to believe that," Tyrian said in a low voice. "Especially that inquisitor… she is extremely wary of you."

"Oh, that much I could feel," Duncan nodded. "She tried to jump down and cut me twice in a row, and failed both times."

Tyrian once again had no idea how to follow that.

Duncan paid no attention to Tyrian's silence. Instead, he turned his gaze toward the daughter in the scrying crystal and asked, as if casually: "Is Lunie with you?"

"She is." Lucretia nodded, then beckoned to the side. Soon, a clockwork doll dressed in a maid outfit appeared in the scrying crystal.

Duncan looked in some surprise at the clockwork automaton in front of him, which no matter how he looked at it did not match Nilu at all: "…Why does she look like this?!"

"I made a few small… modifications to Lunie," Lucretia said, her expression a bit odd as she tried to guess why Father had suddenly changed the subject. "Why did you suddenly ask about her?"

“…I found Nilu,” Duncan said calmly. “In a doll shop. You did not take her with you back then, and she was never sold.”

Lucretia could not help letting out a soft exclamation: “Ah…”

Some distant memories seemed to rise up in the sea witch’s mind. Her expression suddenly grew complicated.

The slight change in her face did not escape Duncan’s eyes.

This was about enough. The groundwork had been laid, and saying more might even weaken the effect.

Duncan’s voice came out of the mirror: “I am leaving.”

Lucretia and Tyrian did not react for a moment. Tyrian spoke without thinking: “Leaving?”

“I still have many things to do,” Duncan said lightly, his eyes finally resting on Lucretia. “I will keep Nilu with me for now. If there is a chance in the future, I will give her to you.”

As his words fell, his figure already began to fade quickly. The ghostly green flames around the edge of the mirror vanished quietly like an illusion, leaving Tyrian and Lucretia no time at all to speak again.

The room fell quiet again. For several minutes after that, neither Lucretia nor Tyrian spoke.

In the end, it was Lucretia who took the initiative to break the silence: “That just now… really happened, right?”

“It wasn’t a hallucination.” Tyrian shook his head with a bitter smile. “Did you ever think all this would happen?”

“…Not even in the strangest dreams,” Lucretia said. Then she suddenly asked, sounding a little tense: “What do you think about all this?”

“You mean…”

“What he just said.” Lucretia spoke with a serious face. “Do you think it is true? Father said he has lost most of his memories, that he even needs to get to know this world again. He also said Subspace’s influence is deep and impossible to get rid of completely… but then he said he has regained his sanity…”

“…To be honest, I don’t dare believe a single word of it, including the part about ‘regaining sanity’,” Tyrian said in a low voice. “Before we have more proof, I would rather believe this is a plot of Subspace.”

“Subspace has no plots,” Lucretia said calmly. “Only humans understand plots.”

“…And what about a human who has gone through Subspace’s baptism?” Tyrian drew a slow breath and shook his head. “When the chaos in Subspace gains intelligence, it will be more terrifying than pure chaos… Of course, things might not be that bad. I also hope sacred miracles have truly appeared. But for now… we should stay observant and wary. You have been working on the border for years. You should know better than I do how necessary that caution is.”

“I understand.” Lucretia was silent for a few seconds, then nodded lightly. Right after, she lifted her gaze again and looked at the oval scrying mirror with a bit of nervousness. “…He really left, right?”

Tyrian thought for a moment, then stepped forward, took the mirror down, and set it face-down on the table.

“I can’t help feeling Father makes me even more nervous than before.” The pirate lord, famous across the seas, muttered under his breath.

Lucretia’s voice immediately came from the scrying crystal: “That’s because he just beat you up. Of course it leaves a deep impression…”

Tyrian turned and glanced back with a blank face: “You’d better watch out. Who knows when Lunie might suddenly start speaking with Father’s voice.”

The scrying crystal went dark at once.

…

In the captain’s cabin of the Vanished, Duncan let out a long breath and went over his exchange with that pair of children.

There should not have been any major omissions.

After he finished reviewing it, he casually picked up paper and pen from beside him and began sketching from memory.

After a few strokes, a hexagonal emblem appeared on the paper.

It was the same strange symbol Tyrian had shown earlier in front of Vanna and Bishop Valentine, the mark carried by those odd ascetics whom Captain Duncan had hosted a hundred years ago.

Through Vanna’s eyes, Duncan had obtained this unexpected piece of information!

Putting down his pen, Duncan looked thoughtfully at the strange hexagon and the broken cross structure inside it, thinking about where he should start to unravel the secret of this symbol.

But suddenly, his gaze froze.

He saw a damp mark suddenly appear on the edge of the paper, as if an invisible stream of water had soaked one corner of it. Then, in the middle of that wet stain, a faint pattern slowly emerged.

It was a single word.

Thank you.

Chapter 236: Hidden Contacts Are a Local Custom

“Thanks.”

It was a very ordinary word, yet it made Duncan’s breath stop for a moment.

He was sure that word had not been on the paper just now, and there had not been that patch of paper blurred by moisture either. All of it had appeared out of thin air right before his eyes.

He stared hard at the new mark on the paper. Around him, a ghostly emerald flame already started to rise. His awareness swept across the whole ship in an instant, to make sure no uninvited “guest” had appeared on board —but he found nothing.

Where had this word come from? Who was sending a message to him? And why?

To be honest, at this moment he felt a bit of what the people he scared must have felt. For example, Vanna back then, when she did a jumping slash at the dressing mirror in her dream; and Tyrian and Lucretia just now. But it was only a bit. Next time he would still do the same.

Right now, the key point was why a single word had suddenly appeared on this sheet of paper.

Duncan frowned hard. Suddenly, a flash of insight lit up in his mind. He thought of one detail. Just now, while he had been talking with Tyrian, he

had joked and said:

“If the God behind this Cathedral is watching, then She owes me a thank-you.”

Duncan’s expression turned strange. His first reaction to this idea was that it was completely absurd. How could a joke like that ever come true? But after that reflex, he could not help following the thought along that path. The more he thought about it… the less calm he felt.

He lowered his head and looked at the damp corner of the paper. After a moment of hesitation, he picked up the fountain pen at his side and wrote a few words in the drier part along the edge of the water stain:

“Storm Goddess?”

After writing, he waited patiently, like a commander who had just pressed the big build button and was waiting for the results. He kept his eyes on that damp patch, full of hope. In the end, the water almost dried up, and no reply appeared.

The other side seemed to have left a message and then slipped away—or maybe had simply read it and chosen not to answer.

Absurd and bizarre thoughts kept popping up in Duncan’s mind. He had stayed in this spooky world for so long, yet this moment still felt stranger than anything before. Even the calm mood he had worked so hard to cultivate was hard to hold. But after he waited a long time and still got nothing, he slowly put down the pen and let himself settle bit by bit.

He stood there and thought for a while. Then he got up and pushed open the wooden door to the enchanted sea chart room. By the chart table, Goathead was, as always, staring at the mist-shrouded enchanted sea chart. It turned its head at once when it heard the door open.

“There wasn’t any anomaly on the ship just now, was there?” Duncan asked at once, not waiting for it to speak first.

“On the ship? There was no anomaly on the ship,” Goathead froze for a second and answered on reflex. Then it seemed to sense something. “What happened? I’ll search the whole ship right away…”

“No need. I’ve already checked once. I just came to you for a second confirmation,” Duncan waved his hand. He steadied himself and decided not to mention the strange words on the paper for now. “I just met with Tyrian and Lucretia—they happened to be contacting each other.”

Goathead felt that the captain’s mood was a little odd at this moment. But since Duncan had no wish to explain, it wisely did not ask. After hearing Duncan’s words, it only sighed a bit: “Many people in the world guessed that Tyrian and Lucretia had a cold sibling relationship. Their proof was that Tyrian worked as a pirate deep inside the civilized seas, while his younger sister was doing great deeds of adventure and exploration on the border of civilization, and the two never met… But now it seems that the world’s random guesses are just guesses in the end.”

“In my view, their relationship is pretty good. Especially when they faced me together. That kind of tacit understanding was clearly built since childhood, from growing up together, and from a childhood scarred by their father’s beatings,” Duncan shook his head. “As for why they’re far apart now… they just chose different paths in life.”

“Ah, the sighs of an old father,” Goathead said in an exaggerated tone. “Did your talk with your pair of ‘children’ go smoothly?”

“…I think it went quite smoothly,” Duncan thought for a moment and nodded slightly. “I believe I have fully shown my goodwill and have planted, at least roughly, an impression of rationality and ‘returning to humanity’ in their minds. I also laid some groundwork for later contact. At

the very least, the next time we run into the Sea Mist, we shouldn’t have to cover each other with fire. That’s the first step toward family harmony.”

Goathead stayed silent for a moment, which Duncan found strange: “Why aren’t you talking this time? You usually talk a lot.”

Goathead spoke in a low voice: “Calling it family harmony just because you’re not firing on each other… that is too powerful. I don’t know how to comment.”

Duncan also did not know how to answer that. He could only spread his hands wordlessly. After a short silence, Goathead asked: “From the sound of it, you are already preparing for the next meeting with Tyrian? Why have you suddenly become so active about this?”

“Because he once served the Frostholm Queen,” Duncan said calmly. “And I’m now curious about that part of his past.”

“Is it because of Miss Alice?”

“A little,” Duncan said offhand.

Then he shook his head, turned, and went back to his room. He found the sheet of paper he had been sketching on and tore off the corner that had been soaked and had words appear on it. Then he returned to the chart table in the enchanted sea chart room: “I have something to show you.”

He placed the strange hexagonal pattern in front of Goathead.

“Have you seen this before?”

Goathead’s neck creaked as it turned. It lowered its gaze and stared curiously at the pattern on the paper. Then it shook its head: “No. What is it?”

“You haven’t seen it?” Duncan frowned. After he made sure Goathead did not seem to be hiding anything, he slowly spoke: “…More than a century

ago, several ascetic monks once visited the Vanished. One of them carried a charm amulet with this pattern on it."

Goathead fell silent for a moment, then spoke softly: "Oh, then that was outside my 'field of view'."

Duncan instantly understood what it meant.

At that time, Goathead had not yet been on the Vanished.

Goathead was not one of the ship's original "crew". It had only served on the Vanished for a century. To be exact, it had appeared on this ship only after the ship crashed into Subspace.

This ship, and this "first mate", hid many secrets. This was one of the few mysteries that Duncan had slowly probed and actually managed to solve.

Duncan said nothing for a while.

He had always been very curious. Curious about how Goathead had come to this ship. Curious why it had become the "first mate" here after the real Captain Duncan had gone completely mad. And… curious about its connection with Subspace, and the countless secrets it knew behind the scenes.

But sadly, Goathead never spoke of these things. Even the few times when Duncan tried to probe a little, it changed the subject in a stiff and obvious way.

That attitude was a hint. It could not say it. If it did, something big and bad would happen.

Duncan pulled his thoughts back and set aside the jumble in his head for now. After thinking for a moment, he nodded to Goathead: "Then keep steering. I need to take care of a few things."

"Of course. At your service, always!"

Duncan put away the paper and turned toward his cabin. He had only walked halfway when he suddenly heard Goathead call from behind: “Captain.”

Duncan stopped and glanced back: “Hm?”

“You can always trust your loyal first mate.”

Duncan did not speak, but he gave a small nod. Then he stepped into his room.

…

Morris had tossed and turned in bed for a long time before he finally sat up.

His wife slept soundly beside him, soft and steady snores rising now and then. The glow of the World’s Wound shone in through the window and spread a sheet of night light across the bedroom floor.

Everything felt like a dream, yet everything was real.

Morris rarely had insomnia, but ever since his wife “returned”, he almost could not fall asleep. And he knew very well why.

Because he was afraid.

He was afraid that if he fell asleep, this dream-like Mortal Realm would really turn into a dream. He was afraid that all these sacred miracles were only his own wishful thinking, just like when he prayed to Subspace eleven years ago and got nothing but an illusion that would pop with one poke.

Because of this fear, he did not even dare to pray to Rahm casually. For many years, even when he had chosen to distance himself from the Church, he had never broken the habit of daily benedictions in his life. But now, because he instinctively avoided the effects of the Eye of Truth’s divine blessing, he even forced himself to stop praying.

Morris let out a light breath and let the cold night air clear his sleepy mind a little. Then he got up, put on a piece of clothing, and stood quietly by the bed, looking at his sleeping wife.

He had done this often in the past two days.

But this time, after he watched for only a short while, his head suddenly felt faint. Right after that, a vague calling and a hazy, dignified figure rose in the depths of his mind. Morris shivered at once and realized what was happening.

The captain was calling him.

The Old Scholar took two deep breaths and woke up fully. Then he walked quickly to the storage room that connected to the master bedroom. He turned on the electric light in the cluttered room, and his eyes went at once to an antique mirror placed in the corner.

Along the edge of the mirror, ethereal spirit form flames slowly floated up. The captain's figure was just beginning to appear within.

For some reason, this was a scene that should have filled an ordinary person with fear, yet it suddenly gave Morris a strange sense of steadiness.

From those floating flames and that solemn figure, he found a sense of "reality". Just as pain could prove that one was alive, this was proof that the sacred miracles had truly happened, proof that the present moment was not false.

Morris walked up to the antique mirror and bent down slightly: "Captain, what do you need of me?"

Duncan saw Morris and the cluttered background behind him. At once, his mind gave him a picture of a middle-aged office drone hiding in the storage room to play games, terrified that his wife would find out…

The next second, he straightened his face and shook off that silly image. He spoke to Morris with a serious expression: “I need you to investigate something. It may have to do with history or some hidden organization.”

“What kind of thing?”

“A mysterious symbol. It once appeared on the amulets of a group of ascetics.”

Chapter 237: The Sleepless

The flames in the mirror faded, and the solemn figure slowly vanished into the darkness, but the mysterious symbol Captain Duncan had shown him still stayed clearly in Morris’s mind.

Morris left the storage room. He glanced at his sleeping wife, then went to the writing desk under the window. He took out paper and pen. By the cold glow of the night outside the window, while his memory was still sharp, he sketched that mysterious, strange symbol.

Then the well-read Old Scholar frowned at the pattern on the paper and sank into brief thought.

Even a scholar who had passed the harshest exams at Truth Academy was completely puzzled when he saw this symbol. There was only one thing he could be sure of: this thing was definitely not a mark used by any city-state, Church, or official group, and it did not fit any rune rules used in occult studies symbolism.

According to the captain, this was the badge carried by a few ascetics who had visited the Vanished a hundred years ago, and now, he had suddenly become interested in that badge.

As the captain’s retainer, Morris did not plan to pry into the captain’s secrets, but he was very curious about those mysterious ascetics. What kind of “people” would carry such a strange charm amulet, and could suddenly draw Captain Duncan’s attention after a hundred years?

After thinking for a long time, Morris let out a slow breath. He folded the paper carefully, put it into the drawer of the writing desk, and locked it with care.

He planned to wait until the Sun rose tomorrow, then go to the study and look through the books on ancient city-states and secret societies. The God of Wisdom had given His believers exceptional memory, but even the best memory had gaps. Maybe there was a record of this symbol somewhere in his collection.

If he could not find clues in his own books, then he would go search the big city libraries and the archives at the Upper City university. He had left his university post many years ago, but his old network and influence were still there. Borrowing a few rare volumes would not be a problem.

If all of Pland still had no record of it, then he could only write letters and send telegrams to old friends in places like Lunsa. A few of his old friends were quite knowledgeable in history and occult studies. Maybe they could help. Even if they could not, the universities and research institutes behind them could.

One way or another, this was the first task the captain had given him. The captain had granted the sacred miracle of True Resurrection, and now he finally had a chance to be of some help.

As Morris made these plans in his heart, the restless mood caused by his insomnia quietly faded away. He felt as if he had returned to his first days at the academy, full of energy and fighting spirit for a clear goal. And along with that fighting spirit…

Came the long-lost drowsiness.

…

Tyrian had been tossing and turning in bed for hours and still felt no trace of sleepiness.

He could no longer remember how many years it had been since he last had such serious insomnia. As the commander of the Sea Mist Fleet and the captain of the Sea Mist, he had always had strong self-control and a good routine. He could fall asleep and wake up with machine-like precision—except for today.

All kinds of thoughts and scenes rose and fell in his mind. Mixed among them were countless yellowed, trivial memories: flames burning in a mirror, his gloomy and solemn father, the expedition ship that had once set sail amid cheers and praise, the silhouette of a warship returning from Subspace…

There was even that clash near Frostholm between the Sea Mist and the Vanished, and the words the Frostholm Queen had said to him at the start of the Abyssal Trench Project—

“There are horrors beneath the Deep Sea, but there must also be every answer beneath the Deep Sea.”

Tyrian turned over and sat up in bed.

He looked toward the nearby wall. The mirror that had hung there had already been taken down and now lay face-down on the table, still and quiet. A lighter oval mark was left on the wall. The suitcase that held the scrying crystal and set of lenses sat at the foot of the bed, locked again. Every place in the room that had a mirror or a smooth, reflective surface had been covered with cloth.

But those white sheets over the mirrors only made the room feel even gloomier and stranger. Under the cold glow of the World’s Wound, the room looked like a place where wraiths gathered.

But Tyrian was not afraid of ghosts. He had an entire ship of living dead sailors, a living warship under the curse, and several secret bases that produced eerie visions all year round. Compared to his father, ghosts were nothing to be afraid of.

He paced back and forth in the quiet, eerie room for a few minutes. Then his eyes fell on the suitcase at the foot of the bed. After a little hesitation, he picked it up.

Polly had already flown back to the ship to report that everything was fine. As a captain, he could not very well run next door to wake up a subordinate to play cards with him. He might as well see what Lucretia was doing.

Maybe she was suffering from insomnia, too.

He turned on the electric light and set the case on the table. When he opened the lid, the scrying crystal, wrapped by a complex lens array and a set of curved connecting arms, appeared before him. Tyrian reached out, but before he could even activate the lenses, the device began to hum. The scrying crystal at its center lit up at once.

In just a moment, Lucretia's figure appeared in the scrying crystal.

The "sea witch" in a gauzy dress, with black hair falling over her shoulders and an air of mystery around her, now only looked at her elder brother with a tired face.

"Brother, I can't sleep."

"If you can't sleep, you can pass the time with your dolls, or go work on your magic experiments," Tyrian said with a straight face, still trying to sound serious. "I'm working on the Sea Mist Fleet's future development plans…"

"But your hair looks like you've been rolling on the pillow for four hours," Lucretia said quietly. "Is that a new pose for drawing up plans?"

“…”

Tyrian was silent for a few seconds, his face full of fatigue: “Do you have any good ideas for treating insomnia? Use your clever witch’s mind… Forget it, pretend I didn’t ask.”

The two siblings fell into an awkward silence for a moment. Then they chatted idly about a few things, both of them purposely avoiding something important. But little by little, the topic still began to drift toward a certain direction.

“…I just made a few ‘adjustments’ to Lunie,” Lucretia said. “I strengthened the protection on her joints, and I added a small container for storing holy oil and some protective charm script next to the sphere that holds her ‘soul’.”

“You think that can block Father from contacting you through ‘Nilu’ next time?”

“No. But it might keep Lunie from freezing up completely next time,” Lucretia said with a hint of helplessness. “She was actually scared by that last freeze. We just had a serious talk about it.”

Tyrian was a little curious: “Talk? What did you and your doll talk about?”

“She told me not to be nervous. I told her to take it easy.”

Tyrian: “…”

They fell silent again, but this time it did not last long before Tyrian suddenly said: “Actually, I was just thinking about something.”

“Thinking about what?”

“Do you still remember what Father said at the end today?” Tyrian said slowly. “He said he had found Lunie’s sister, ‘Nilu’. He also mentioned that doll had never been sold…”

Lucretia's eyes changed a little: "You mean…"

"It means that shop is still there. Do you still remember where that doll shop was?" Tyrian's face grew serious. "All I remember is that it was somewhere inside Pland."

Lucretia frowned slightly and fell into memory. Tyrian went on, slowly: "If Father really 'bought' Nilu from that doll shop, then that reveals a key piece of information: before he met the historical corruption in Pland, he had already set foot in this city-state in some way, and had even been moving around here in the open…"

"Have you thought that this might be a clue Father revealed to us on purpose?" Lucretia suddenly said. "Now you've thought of all this, but maybe this is exactly what Father wants you to investigate."

Tyrian was quiet for a few seconds before he spoke: "I have considered that. But even so, you know I won't let this clue go."

"…I only vaguely remember where the shop was," Lucretia said. "It should be at the edge of the Upper City, near a crossroads by the southern subordinate district. The shopkeeper was an elven lady… When I saw her a century ago, she already seemed quite old. But given an elf's lifespan, the owner of that shop is probably still her."

Tyrian gave a small nod and quietly memorized the information Lucretia gave him.

…

The sea had picked up a little. The Vanished rocked gently in the waves. Duncan sat at the chart table, studying the mist-covered enchanted sea chart in front of him out of sheer boredom.

His body in the city-state of Pland had already gone to sleep, but this "true body" on the Vanished barely needed rest. As a result, the night voyage had

become a very boring stretch of time. On top of that, night was not suitable for reading, and the sea was not suitable for reading either, so he could not even bring over the light reading he had bought in Pland to pass the time. The boredom only grew.

After all, he could not treat exploring the ship as a fun game every day. No matter how big the Vanished was, exploration had an end.

“I’m almost tempted to walk the Spirit Realm knocking on glass, and call Vanna and Tyrian up to play cards,” Duncan sighed in his boredom. He lifted his eyelids and looked at Goathead. “Vanna is another matter, but Tyrian is most likely not sleeping tonight…”

“If you really do that, he won’t sleep tomorrow night either,” Goathead said at once. “But honestly, your idea is very attractive. It has both full horror value and great entertainment value. Who are you planning to knock on first?”

“I’m just talking,” Duncan shot Goathead a glance. His eyes passed over the enchanted sea chart again. Then, all of a sudden, he seemed to remember something and jerked his head up. “How long until sunrise?”

“…About three hours,” Goathead estimated. “If it rises on time today.”

Chapter 238: The Radiant Star's Pursuit

There were still three hours before the Sun would rise from the far edge of the sea. The relatively safe and stable daylight would replace the unsettling veil of night – if the Sun really rose normally at all.

Duncan glanced at the mechanical clock hanging not far away. Its hands were ticking along at an unhurried pace.

Goathead's voice suddenly sounded: "Are you planning to wait for sunrise? There are still three hours left."

"…Sitting here for three hours doing nothing is even more boring than staring at this enchanted sea chart that is almost blank," Duncan shook his head. He stood up, rolled his shoulders, and slowly walked toward the bedroom. "I'll go rest for a while. If I still haven't come out before sunrise, you can just call me."

"Happy to serve you."

Duncan nodded, pushed the door open, and returned to the bedroom. He casually threw the sheet of paper covered with mysterious emblem patterns onto the table, then walked toward the bed not far away.

This body of his almost did not need rest, but every now and then he still took a short nap before dawn came – not to ease any real fatigue, but simply so he could "get up and greet the sunrise".

It let him keep a feeling of being “alive” aboard the Vanished, so he would not slowly lose his own humanity on this ghost ship. Even though he did not know whether there was really any danger of that, once he had noticed that the Vanished was not as stable as he had imagined, he had been consciously keeping up this habit of “maintaining human ways of living on the ship”.

Duncan lay down and closed his eyes. In his ears he heard the low whisper of wind and waves from the sea surface. Under his body he felt the constant slight rocking of the great ship. Bit by bit, he forced himself to relax.

…

On the Radiant Star, in the captain’s quarters that were arranged with a distinctly feminine touch, Lucretia, wearing a silk nightgown, suddenly sat up in bed.

Her hair was a bit messy. Her face showed a trace of fatigue and irritation. As she sat up, she was still holding a huge stuffed rabbit doll half as tall as a person, its shape comical yet faintly eerie.

The doll was pieced together from pink and blue fabric. A scar ran across its face, and its jagged mouth was smeared with a strange, blood-red color. At the moment Lucretia sat up, the stuffed rabbit doll twitched a little, then slowly turned its head. Its button eyes looked toward its mistress, and from its cotton-filled body came a little girl’s voice: “Mistress, I thought you had finally fallen asleep…”

Lucretia glanced at the clock beside her and spoke in a slightly annoyed tone: “I slept for a few dozen minutes at best and then got scared awake by a bad dream… What time is it now?”

“Two hours before sunrise,” the stuffed rabbit doll said as it jumped down from its mistress’s arms to the floor. It hopped over to the cabinet, used its

soft plush paw to open the door, took out the captain’s treasured wine, poured a small glass, and held it up to Lucretia. “You could still sleep a bit more – this will help calm your mind.”

Lucretia took the glass and drained it in one gulp, but she still stood up: “No need. Lying there will only make me more irritated… Help me get ready.”

“All right, Mistress.”

The stuffed rabbit doll with the little girl’s voice answered crisply. It took the glass from its mistress’s hand and put it away, then began hopping around, tidying the bed, clearly very used to the routine.

At the same time, Lucretia snapped her fingers, and the lights in the room came on. She let out a slow breath, dragged her steps over to the dressing table, and tapped a drawer beneath the mirror with a fingernail. At once, the drawer slid open.

A wooden toy seaman jumped out. The seaman wore a navy uniform from an ancient age and held a tiny command sword in his hand. He first bowed to Lucretia, then stood on top of the drawer and waved his sword, shouting sharp little orders.

A whole crowd of toy soldiers rushed out of the drawer. They quickly formed up and did a roll call, then ran to the side to pick up a comb, a hand mirror, a water cup, and a toothbrush. Lined up in order, they ran nimbly onto Lucretia’s body or the back of the chair behind her and began carrying out their mistress’s morning wash.

Lucretia sat listlessly in front of the dressing table and let the dolls fuss around her. She herself was fighting the fatigue and pressure brought on by a sleepless night and wild thoughts. At the same time she absentmindedly

turned over matters related to the Vanished. After quite a while, she took a deep breath and forced her mind to clear.

Just then, a faint thread of golden light slipped in through the crack in the curtains not far away and fell into the sight of this “sea witch”.

Lucretia saw that ray of light. At first she did not react, but after only two or three seconds her eyes suddenly narrowed. She quickly looked toward the mechanical clock at the side.

There was still one hour before sunrise.

This was not the time for the Sun to rise!

She suddenly stood up.

The toy seamen had a brief moment of confusion, then, as if long trained, they packed everything away while reforming their ranks. The stuffed rabbit doll, which had already finished tidying the bed, noticed its mistress’s movement and hopped over: “Mistress, it looks like it’s getting light outside!”

“It’s not time to get light yet,” Lucretia said quickly as she strode toward the window. “Where are we right now?”

“We’re still sailing along the route we set last night,” the stuffed rabbit doll answered at once. “We’re already close to the place where that big thing fell last time!”

The moment the stuffed rabbit finished speaking, Lucretia yanked open the thick curtains and then opened the window, which was reinforced with a fine metal mesh.

A thin, hazy fog floated over the sea outside. This was the most common sight in the border region. Deep within that fog, a vast patch of faint golden

light was quietly drifting on the surface of the sea. For the moment, it was impossible to tell how far it was from the Radiant Star.

A massive glowing monster floated on the surface of the sea.

Lucretia stared hard in that direction, then took a deep breath. Her body suddenly turned into a flurry of flying colored paper. The colored scraps rushed out through the open window, swept across the deck, passed through stairwells, and flew into the wheelhouse on the upper middle deck.

Inside the wheelhouse, Lunie, a clockwork automaton dressed in a maid's uniform, was at the helm. She sensed her mistress at once. As the colored scraps flew in and swirled, Lunie had already let go of the wheel. In the next second, Lucretia's figure condensed out of the paper and reached out to take the helm.

"Mistress, I was just about to send someone to fetch you," Lunie said as she stepped aside. "That patch of golden light suddenly appeared out of the fog. From the position, it should be the fallen relic we've been tracking."

"Bring us up to full speed. All hands on standby. Have the stern ready to dive into the Spirit Realm at any time," Lucretia said quickly. "Are our reserves of Aetheric Dust and Witch Oil full?"

Lunie answered just as fast: "Reserves are full. Your orders have already been passed on."

Lucretia nodded, and at once the Radiant Star awakened completely under her command.

Large numbers of clockwork sailors, automata, and ceramic soldiers rushed to their posts. The special paddle wheels on both sides of the hull began to spin faster and faster. That engine system, which looked behind the times, slowly unleashed power greater than any modern screw engine and pushed the ship's speed up quickly. At the back half of the ship, the ghostlike

“original hull” became even more vague and unreal. Strands of blackness as thin as hair spread from the stern out into the surrounding waters. Seen from afar, it looked as if a black wake were stretching out behind the Radiant Star.

Under Lucretia’s own hands, the whole ship showed a form where magic and machinery coexisted, where beauty and grace were mixed with horror and ugliness.

As the Radiant Star’s speed rose further, the huge golden glowing orb floating between the thin fog and the sea surface finally came into clearer and clearer view before Lucretia’s eyes.

At the same time, its true, ever-growing scale revealed itself.

Even Lunie, the clockwork automaton, slowly widened her eyes and could not help letting out a soft gasp: “Heavens… Mistress, what is that?”

Lucretia did not answer. She only stared fixedly ahead at the giant golden phantom that was slowly emerging from the mist, already as large as a small mountain.

It was so big that from any single angle it was almost impossible to make out its full shape. It was so solemn and perfect that it did not look like anything humans could have built.

A huge and intricate golden geometric body floated quietly on the sea. Its entire mass glowed with a soft, soul-stirring pale gold light. Its height was more than three times that of the Radiant Star’s tallest mast. Its two sides stretched out like fortress walls. The upper half slanted slightly outward like a terrifying cliff. There were no extra bumps or details on its surface. Every part of it seemed seamless and whole.

As they got closer, Lucretia and Lunie began to see more details of the enormous thing.

“It looks half transparent,” Lunie said curiously as she leaned close to the broad viewing window. “It looks… like a glowing piece of stained glass?”

“…No, it doesn’t seem like it’s just transparent…” Lucretia shook her head. She stared ahead without blinking, as if she had noticed something wrong at the edges of the huge glowing geometric body. At that moment, a small black dot suddenly flew out of the nearby fog and entered her field of view.

It was a seabird – even on the Boundless Sea, even in this border full of strange phenomena, creatures like that still existed.

In fact, because they did not have complex intelligence like humans, these “wild animals” tended to live even better than those brave and powerful explorers in the eerie border waters.

Lucretia’s gaze was drawn to the seabird. She noticed that the poor thing seemed to have had its mind scrambled by the golden light on the sea. In its panic, it flew straight toward that glowing “mountain”.

Yet the next second, the expected violent crash and fall did not happen. The bird flew right in, into that slightly slanted “cliff face”.

A little later, in the corner of Lucretia’s eye, she saw that same bird fly out from another direction, looking completely unharmed.

Lunie had also seen it. The clockwork automaton muttered in surprise: “… Is that a phantom?”

Chapter 239: fallen relic

The Radiant Star’s speed slowly dropped. In the end, the ship stopped carefully on the sea a few hundred meters from the glowing, half-transparent “cliff face”.

But compared to the size of that colossal object, a few hundred meters was almost nothing. To Lunie, it still felt as if the Radiant Star had already come right up against the cliff. The towering geometric body before them loomed like a mountain, pressing down with a crushing sense of scale. If an ordinary person stood here… they might already be struggling to breathe.

“…It’s really spectacular,” the clockwork automaton could not help saying as she craned her neck. “And it’s very beautiful.”

The thing really was both spectacular and beautiful. Ignoring its strangeness, it could have been called a magnificent wonder, enough to give a great artist the greatest inspiration of a lifetime, or enough to make a poet compose countless verses.

It looked like a sharp-edged mountain carved from clear pale golden amber, or like an especially regular geometric iceberg. It drifted in the water, surrounded by a misty glow. The thin fog in the area slowly flowed along its surface, tracing out a dreamlike aura.

And all signs showed that this thing really was as “dreamlike” as it appeared. It had no solid body. Even though it clearly existed there, it seemed to be nothing more than a massive shadow.

“Mistress,” Lunie could not help turning her head. “What do you think this thing is?”

“…I don’t know. I only know that it fell from the sky.” Lucretia admitted frankly. She recalled the scene when the Radiant Star had first begun to track it. It had been the day before yesterday, in the last few hours of daylight. While on patrol, the Radiant Star had seen a huge, hazy glowing orb suddenly fall from the sky, tear through the clouds, and vanish into the depths of the border sea. From that moment on, she and her ship had been following it.

But aside from the obvious fact that it had “fallen from the sky”, she knew nothing about this phantom visitor from beyond the world.

Lucretia carefully studied the base of the huge geometric body and confirmed one more thing:

This thing was light, very, very light. It floated on the sea, with only a small part of its lower half dipping into the water. Yet that slight sinking still showed that this “phantom” thing did have some mass and was not just a flat shadow.

Having at least some mass meant it could be bound by matter in the Mortal Realm… With the Radiant Star’s power, maybe they could even tow it away.

Could they drag it back into the territory of the civilized world and assemble a truly professional team to study it? The Explorers’ Association would likely be happy to help…

But that was only theory. How could they actually do it? How do you drag a gigantic phantom that things could pass through? Or… was there some solid core deep inside this glowing geometric body, and that was where its mass came from?

Lucretia’s thoughts raced. Lunie’s voice sounded at her side: “Should we try exploring the inside?”

“We start with caution.” Lucretia spoke as she lifted her hand and bit her finger. A drop of blood welled from her fingertip and slowly floated forward. Halfway there, it suddenly burst with a “pop” into a dramatic cloud of smoke.

When the smoke cleared, another “Lucretia” appeared in the wheelhouse – but it was only a ghostlike phantom. She wore a torn, deathly white long dress. Her face was stiff and grim. Her whole form was half transparent, drifting eerily in midair.

Lucretia nodded to the phantom. Without a word, the ghost turned around and flew toward the “mountain” a few hundred meters away.

Lunie watched, slightly tense, as the ghostly double swept over the foggy sea and then slipped without a sound into the inside of the “mountain”.

Nothing happened.

“Mistress?” Lunie looked back at her master. “What is inside?”

“Light and heat. Very warm, but not scorching. Bright, but not blinding… Inside there is no wind or waves. The sea surface below seems even calmer than ‘outside’,” Lucretia said, speaking slowly as she carefully sensed the information coming from the phantom double. “For now it looks like at least the shallow layer of the ‘mountain’ is safe. I’m speeding up toward the inner part.”

Lunie nodded. Though she was only a clockwork automaton, she had a “soul” closer to that of a human than any other crew member on the ship. At this moment, she could not help feeling nervous. She reached back and turned her own key twice to relieve the tiny shiver running through her

inner parts from the tension. After that, she waited for a long time before she finally saw her mistress's expression change.

Lucretia frowned slightly and looked up ahead.

"I've reached the deepest part," the "sea witch" said. "There is a core."

"A core? What kind?"

"A huge stone sphere," Lucretia said, looking a bit puzzled. "Or at least, it looks like it's made of some stone-like material. Gray-white, with many regular grooves on the surface. About ten meters in diameter, floating in the air above the sea…"

As she spoke, Lucretia furrowed her brow and focused, as if she were giving new orders to the ghostly phantom that had entered deep into the glowing geometric body. Then she went on: "It can be touched. It's solid."

"It's solid…" Lunie froze for a second. Years of working together let her understand at once what her mistress meant. "You want to… drag it back?"

"The elven scholars of Lightwind Harbor should be interested in this thing," Lucretia said calmly. "The lines on the stone sphere's surface have a clear pattern and hide a complex geometric structure. I guess… someone good at mathematics could see something in it."

"Then how are we supposed to 'drag' it back?" Lunie stared at her mistress in disbelief. "With a rope or a chain? We do have spare anchor cables on the ship, but they might not be long enough – the projection of that glowing orb is too big. The distance from here to its core probably already exceeds the limit of the cables…"

Lucretia silently watched the glowing "mountain". After half a minute, it was as if she had made up her mind: "We'll go in and pull it."

"…Are you serious?"

“My curiosity is up.”

“…All right, you are serious.”

…

Duncan lay asleep in the captain’s quarters of the Vanished and had a short yet bizarre dream.

It was unbelievable. This body of his hardly needed sleep at all, much less dreamed. In fact, ever since he had come to this ship, he had never once “dreamed”. The body in Pland had experienced some scattered and messy dreams, but none had ever been as clear or as deeply etched in his memory as this strange short dream.

In the dream, he saw meteors – meteors that appeared suddenly in broad daylight.

He stood at the bow of the Vanished. The whole ship was dead silent. He could not hear Goathead’s nagging in his mind. He could not hear Alice’s daily racket on the deck as she fought with buckets and mops. Even the entire Boundless Sea was silent, with no waves and no wind.

The whole world seemed to have fallen into deathly stillness. In that silence, a huge glowing orb fell from the sky – also silent and soundless.

glowing orbs fell one after another, striking the calm surface of the Boundless Sea. They were enormously huge fallen relics, yet they did not stir up even the slightest ripple, as if one phantom were falling onto another. Those glowing orbs gradually began to fall like rain and finally turned into a terrifying and grotesque meteor shower. Countless glowing orbs slowly covered the entire sea surface, surrounding the Vanished in a field of radiance.

Yet as the countless glowing orbs fell, the sky grew dimmer and dimmer. By the end of the dream, as the meteor shower slowly faded, the sky had

become pitch black.

At the end of the dream, Duncan raised his head and saw that only a single dark red, mottled, horrible hole remained in the heavens, like an ember not yet gone cold in the dark. It hung there like a dying eye, quietly staring down at all things in the world.

Duncan snapped his eyes open. The deep impression left by that absurd nightmare still burned strongly in his mind.

He was shocked that he had actually dreamed on this ship, and even more shocked by the strange scenes he had seen in the dream.

A silent world, silent meteors, a sky of dead darkness, and that terrible hole in the heavens, staring down like an eye… Why would he dream of something so strange? What did this dream mean?

Duncan slowly calmed his breathing and sat up in bed, rubbing his forehead in irritation.

On this eerie Boundless Sea, on the Vanished, he could not bring himself to believe that a dream was just a simple dream. Something must have affected him, or his own “intuition” must have sensed something, for him to see that scene in his sleep.

As he brooded in agitation, he frowned slightly.

Was it related to the “World Countdown” he had just learned about? Was it connected to the “truth” of the world’s Doomsday that the “Captain Duncan” from a hundred years ago had touched?

Was it just his mind connecting the dots after suddenly learning all that, or was it the remaining memories in this body stirring up again? Was his contact with Tyrian and Lucretia related to this dream?

Duncan tapped his forehead lightly with his fingers, then reached toward the bottle on the cabinet beside the bed, planning to use a bit of alcohol to steady his nerves. But just as he stretched out his hand, his gaze swept across the Chronometer Clock on the wall not far away, and his movement stopped.

The hands on the Chronometer Clock had stopped.

They had stopped at the moment when there was still one minute before sunrise.

Outside the window, everything was dim. He could not see the glow of dawn, yet there was also no cold light from the World's Wound.

The flame of the oil lamp in the bedroom was the only "living thing" still burning calmly, but the light it cast seemed faintly pale, making the room's illumination feel a bit strange.

Duncan's gaze moved calmly over all of this, taking in every unusual detail.

Something was obviously wrong… Was he still dreaming?

He quickly ruled that out. With his mind clear again, Duncan could still tell whether he was dreaming or not.

He frowned and held himself back from the impulse to open the window and look at the outside of the ship. Instead, he got up and walked to the wooden door of the bedroom.

He would go to the enchanted sea chart room first and see if Goathead knew what was going on.

He opened the door to the enchanted sea chart room and looked toward the chart table where the enchanted sea chart and Goathead should have been.

Goathead was not there.

Chapter 240: An Impossible Sight Ahead

Goathead was not there.

This was even more unbelievable than that absurd, eerie dream.

Duncan stood frozen in the doorway for a long time before he slowly came back to his senses. Then he drew the sword at his waist and moved forward, fully on guard.

Goathead really was gone. Only the enchanted sea chart and a few odds and ends lay on the familiar chart table, and the spot where Goathead had once sat was nothing but bare tabletop.

Duncan stared at the empty tabletop for a few seconds before slowly looking away. Then he lifted his head and looked around.

Even more wrong-looking details came into view.

Everything in the room looked mottled and old. Cracks of different depths covered the walls and pillars. Many items were missing from the nearby shelves; almost nothing was left but bare frames. The wall that had once held a decorative tapestry now showed only a suspicious, black stain. Beside that stain was a window, filthy and grimy. Outside it was dim and chaotic. Now and then, a suspicious glimmer flashed past.

It was as if some very fast-moving shadows were darting through the air outside the glass.

The whole enchanted sea chart room felt as if it had been abandoned for many years. Time had ruined most of the furnishings here, and some rough force, more dangerous than time itself, had left those deep and shallow, dark marks on every wall, the ceiling, and the floor.

Duncan even pinched his own thigh again, unable to stop himself, wanting to make sure once more that he was not dreaming.

The sharp pain and his clear thoughts reminded him at the same time that this was not a dream, but the Mortal Realm. A Mortal Realm that felt… very strange to him.

The feeling from his first step onto the Vanished surged up again. Surrounded by endless weirdness, Duncan felt his brow slowly furrow.

But compared to that first time on this ship, he adjusted much faster now. After a few deep breaths, he was completely calm.

After all, he now had many strange experiences that he could never have imagined in the first half of his life. The experience he had gained dealing with this eerie world, and the control and confidence he had in his own power, meant he was no longer that confused rookie from before.

Now the only thing that truly worried him was that his fear that the Vanished was unstable and would run into trouble sooner or later seemed to be turning into fact.

This ship had changed in some abnormal way.

Duncan walked another circle around the room. He checked the now-empty shelves, looked over the walls that were nothing but grime, and glanced at the corner where two wooden chests had once stood. Most things were gone. Aside from the chart table, the place had almost become an old, ruined empty room.

But one more thing still sat in its original place: the Oval Scrying Mirror with the ornate patterned frame.

Duncan walked to the mirror and cautiously looked into it.

No terrible scene appeared. The mirror did not show a bloody hell or any twisted, deformed face. It was just very dirty. Dark stains covered the glass, yet in the cleaner patches he could still see his reflection normally.

Duncan did not stay before the mirror for long. He went back to the chart table and let his gaze sweep over the enchanted sea chart.

In the next second, his eyes suddenly froze.

The enchanted sea chart had changed too!

The fog that had once covered almost the whole chart had almost completely vanished. With the mist gone, clear and complex sailing routes showed on the parchment.

Duncan leaned in without thinking, trying to make out the details on the enchanted sea chart, but he soon sensed that something was wrong.

Lines crisscrossed the enchanted sea chart, routes tangled over one another. Yet he could not see a single meaningful mark or place. It looked more like a mess of lines drawn at random, recording a muddled sleepwalk. Between those lines there were no islands, no city-states… nothing at all.

He could not see Pland, could not see Lunsa, could not see Cold Harbor or Qingfeng… Most of those city-state names were still strange to him, but at least he knew they existed and should definitely appear on this enchanted sea chart now that the mist was gone.

Duncan’s frown grew deeper. After he realized there was no landmark at all on the enchanted sea chart that he could use, he slowly straightened up and tilted his head, listening for any sound outside the window.

There was no movement outside. No wind, no waves. Only silence… just like that strange, brief nightmare.

The lines on the enchanted sea chart marked the sailing track of the Vanished. Those tracks updated themselves as the ship drifted. So the lines now marked on this mist-cleared, crisscrossed enchanted sea chart… from which dimension of the Vanished's voyage were they taken?

Duncan let out a soft breath. Then, as if he had made up his mind, he turned with sword in hand and walked toward the captain's cabin door. In theory, beyond that door lay the deck of the Vanished.

He gripped the handle, took a deep breath, and pushed the door open.

The Vanished sailed through a dark, hazy chaos. Everywhere he could see, the deck and the structures on the ship were in ruins, long since abandoned.

At least, beyond the door it really was the deck of the Vanished.

Duncan stepped out through the door. His boots landed on a deck full of pits and cracks, as if it were close to collapsing. A harsh creak sounded at once, breaking the suffocating stillness.

He moved forward carefully at first. Only after he confirmed that the deck only looked ruined and was not actually about to cave in did he dare to walk a bit more boldly. Then he lifted his head to take in the surroundings of the Vanished.

Before his eyes stretched a barren, boundless expanse of chaotic space. Dim shadows hung everywhere. Between those shadows, gloomy, blurry currents of light appeared from time to time and then slowly faded. Now and then a strange flash or stream of light would suddenly flare bright, like a blind bolt of lightning that lit up the distant void. In that brief flash, he could faintly see some huge things floating in the emptiness, as if they were slowly turning and writhing.

The moment he saw those dark lights and flickering streams, Duncan could only curse in his heart.

This scene… looked a bit familiar.

It was exactly the same as the view beneath the hull of the Vanished—Subspace!

Duncan almost swore out loud. The corner of his mouth twitched twice. He thought that the thing he feared most would always be the first to happen. Not long ago he had been worrying that Subspace was too cursed and seemed to be calling to him, and that he needed to find a way to avoid touching it. Yet now, with just one blink, he had somehow ended up on a Subspace drift—how had he suddenly ended up here?!

But after the first wave of panic, he quickly calmed down and held back the urge to turn around and run back into the captain's cabin.

He still could not be sure this really was Subspace. It only felt very similar to what he had seen outside the hull of the Vanished. And if this place truly was Subspace… then hiding back in the captain's cabin would be pointless.

Besides that, he soon noticed something suspicious about his own condition.

He stood there, looking up at the scenery of this supposed Subspace, and felt no discomfort at all. His mind did not feel corrupted, and he heard no strange sounds. Yet by the "common sense" of this world… humans were not just unable to enter Subspace. Wasn't simply looking at Subspace supposed to drive a person mad on the spot?

But he did not feel even the slightest discomfort.

Not only did he feel fine, he could still clearly sense his body back in Pland and sense Nina, Morris, Vanna, and the other "marks" he had left in the Mortal Realm.

Even if he, as a “ghost captain”, had some special traits and some resistance to Subspace, he still should not have been this… safe in a place like this, right?

Puzzled by his own state, Duncan even started to doubt whether this really was the so-called Abyss of World’s End. Then he steadied himself and walked toward the railing at the edge of the deck.

He came to the ship’s side and leaned out to look.

As he had expected, there was no sea beneath the Vanished. The ship seemed to be floating in space, surrounded by the same void in every direction.

He stood at the edge of the deck, gazing at the hazy, massive shadows in the distance and the streams of light that flared from time to time, and carefully planned how he should get out of this situation.

First, he had to confirm whether this place really was Subspace. Second, he had to look for and confirm whether there was still any link between here and the Mortal Realm.

Since he could come here, that meant there had to be some place that reconnected this space with the Mortal Realm. But that place did not have to be in the bedroom where he had woken up. He had already checked both the bedroom and the enchanted sea chart room and found no trace of any such “passage”.

After a moment of thought, he formed a rough plan. He turned away from the rail and walked toward the hatchway in the middle of the deck.

Just then, something caught the corner of Duncan’s eye, and he stopped without thinking.

He lifted his head and looked toward where his peripheral vision had just flicked. A slightly bright arc of electricity was slowly fading in the distant

darkness. In that dying glow, he could faintly see some huge, lump-like thing slowly drifting over the Vanished.

Duncan stared hard. At that moment, another “flash” appeared. It was like a long, winding bolt of lightning that stretched across the high sky and lit up an enormous patch of “heaven” in an instant.

Duncan finally saw a hint of the giant shape’s outline—and his breath caught at once.

It was a piece of land… or rather a shadow of broken land. Its scale was unimaginably huge, large enough to trigger a fear of giant things in anyone. Its uneven outline looked as if some vast force had torn it straight off a planet and then hurled it here.

On that upside-down land he could even dimly see mountains, rivers, and some other lines that looked even stranger and more unsettling. But all of it had lost color and life. The entire “continent” was only a flat gray-black. The rivers lay frozen in the gullies of the earth. It looked like a rough model stripped of every shade of color, sealed into a lump of motionless amber in time and space.

This huge fragment of a celestial body moved slowly over the Vanished, showing Duncan some bleak, ancient image of doomsday.

Chapter 241: The Other Side

The whole continent hung upside down, slowly moving over his head. Its huge, gloomy shadow covered four-fifths of his view. The pressure from that sight was shocking. Even Duncan felt almost suffocated and could not help wanting to look away.

But he forced himself not to. Instead, he made himself keep his head raised and studied that upside-down fragment of a star even more closely.

He did not know what this place was, how he had come here, or how he was supposed to get back. That was exactly why he had to watch every strange thing and gather every bit of information that might help.

Did that hanging celestial wreck actually exist? Or was it only a terrible illusion? Was it the corpse of some broken world, or just something twisted out as a projection by the warped time and space of Subspace?

The upside-down land drifted along a slanted path, moving closer and closer to the Vanished. Duncan suddenly grew tense. He noticed that the ship beneath his feet seemed to be moving right along the edge of that “continent”. The two might actually collide!

But just as the continent drew nearer and the stern of the Vanished was about to brush a broken mountain on its edge, Duncan suddenly felt the deck under his feet tremble.

Right after that, he seemed to hear faint cries coming from nowhere. Harsh creaks rose from every part of the old, damaged ghost ship. The sounds broke the stillness on the Vanished. In the next second, the huge hull under

his feet began to turn ever so slightly. With a distance that was narrow and then narrower still, the upper works of the Vanished slid past the broken peak.

Duncan stared in shock at the ship's movements and listened as those ghostly cries and creaks slowly faded back into silence. Then, all of a sudden, something seemed to flicker at the edge of his vision. He jerked his head up and looked at the broken mountain at the edge of the upside-down continent—

By now the Vanished had slowly moved past the mountain's middle line. The ship's worn masts almost brushed the dark, shadowy peak. Now Duncan could see what lay behind the mountain.

He saw a cliff, jagged as if it had been torn apart by brute force. A huge humanoid being leaned against that cliff. "He" was almost as tall as the whole mountain. His limbs were long, thin, and pale. His head was swollen and misshapen. A single giant eye was set in his pitted face. That eye was half open, half shut. Filthy fluid seeped from it and hung in midair, frozen like drops of amber.

This one-eyed giant had clearly been dead for countless years, yet the body that remained still seemed to radiate some soul-gripping pressure and power. There were no clear wounds on "him". It looked as if he had died from sheer exhaustion. Even in death, his hands still braced hard against the cliff behind him, his fingers driven deep into the rock.

The colorless black continent and the pale, one-eyed giant dead on the cliff at its edge, all in this dark, chaotic Subspace and lit by that long streak of "lightning"—this stark black-and-white scene burned itself deep into Duncan's mind.

After that, the flash that had lasted so long finally began to fade. It had cut across the center of the continent and now slowly shrank from that center.

In Duncan’s sight, the upside-down land gradually fell back into darkness.

But he still kept his head raised. He knew the continent had not fully moved away yet. Its last far edge was still drifting slowly above the Vanished. He almost felt he could hear a deep rumble as that vast weight rolled over his head. He knew it was only his imagination, yet that phantom roar kept echoing in his mind, like the last sigh of a dead world left behind in Subspace.

At last Duncan lowered his gaze and slowly looked around at the vast chaos beyond the ship’s rail.

From time to time, streams of light and shadow rose and faded. Bright flashes now and then tore through the dark. In this murky void, those flashes and flows sometimes lit up things—lumps of every size, nameless shadows.

Duncan drew in a slow breath and looked down at the ship under his feet—the Vanished, so different from the one he knew, ruined in every part.

He closed his eyes a little and tried to communicate with this ship, just as he had with the intact Vanished in the Mortal Realm, to understand this ghost ship drifting in Subspace.

But in the next second, he snapped his eyes open.

He could not feel the ship. It was not that he could not talk to it. He could not sense its existence at all!

The moment his awareness spread out, he “felt” the ship beneath him vanish. There was no deck, no masts, no cabins. He even felt as if he were drifting alone in this vast chaos. The huge emptiness and the distorted sense of things that followed shattered his focus at once.

Duncan stared in surprise at the ship’s structure around him, then lifted a foot and stamped on the deck, as if he could not believe that the ship

carrying him might only be a phantom.

Or… was he the one who was a phantom?

For a moment, Duncan's mind filled with tangled thoughts. Then he shook his head and walked toward the door that led down below the deck.

He decided to keep going with his plan of exploration.

No matter what was going on with this ship, no matter why it seemed "nonexistent" to his senses, it was at least holding him up now. It did not show any wish to throw off or reject its "captain". That gave Duncan the drive and confidence to keep exploring.

He went down the steps and entered the open hold below the deck.

He opened several cabins in a row. Inside each one was the same old, broken scene. Suspicious black stains mottled the walls and ceiling. Every room was empty. Some of these had clearly been storerooms stuffed full of things in his memory, but now they held only damaged walls and support pillars.

He even went and found the cabin where Alice had lived. Of course, it was just as empty. For some reason, that actually made him feel relieved.

Rather than meet familiar people or things here, he much preferred that they did not appear in this creepy, terrifying place.

After leaving Alice's room, Duncan went straight through the crew quarters and the dining area, heading deeper into the ship.

When he crossed the middle deck of storerooms, he paused for a couple of minutes before the stairs that led farther down.

On the Vanished in the Mortal Realm, he had explored those areas before. He knew that below lay the cabin of light-and-shadow Inversion and,

deeper still, the “broken bilge”. But during that exploration, he had carried a special consecrated lantern.

That consecrated lantern had helped him expand his senses and reveal in advance the twisted, warped corners of the cabins that were dangerous.

But here, he had not found that lantern.

After only a short hesitation, Duncan still chose to go on.

Things here had changed so much from the Mortal Realm that even if he found the consecrated lantern, it might not work in the cabins below. Besides, the lantern’s main power was to extend his senses. But in his senses this ship did not exist at all. What good would it do to push that sense out several times farther?

Duncan simply raised the sword in his hand and slid his fingers lightly through the air above the blade. A faint green flame flared along the edge, giving him a little light.

Using the sword as a lamp, he went down the steps and walked forward slowly.

A broad, dark cabin came into view.

This was the cabin of light-and-shadow Inversion. In the Mortal Realm, oil lamps had burned everywhere in this room, but the light from the lamps and the darkness in the corners followed the rules of an Inversion of light. The places with more light had been darker, while the corners with no lamps had shone brighter.

Duncan looked around.

Here there was no light-and-shadow Inversion. There was only a flat, chaotic dimness. The spirit form flame burning on his sword did not trigger any strange Inversion effect. It simply lit up the area in a normal way.

Duncan couldn’t help muttering under his breath: “…This place is a lot more normal.”

Then he walked carefully across the empty space and kept going until another staircase came into view.

This staircase led down to the bilge of the Vanished, the place that had been broken into pieces.

Standing before the stairs, Duncan drew in a soft breath and stepped down.

A door appeared at the foot of the stairs.

Duncan lifted his head without thinking and looked at the doorframe. He still remembered the words that had once been written there, saying that this was the last door at the bottom of the ship.

There was nothing on the frame now.

There was no warning left for those who came after, no message to guide the way. It was only an ordinary wooden door, standing slightly open as if welcoming visitors to step inside.

Duncan was not very surprised. He only drew back his gaze in silence, gripped his burning sword with one hand, and slowly pushed the door open with the other.

On the other side of the door lay another dim place, an old, damaged cabin.

But it was whole.

Duncan stepped inside and at once noticed the intact walls all around. Though the place was worn and shabby, there was not a single gap in the hull here, and of course nothing could be seen beyond it.

The bilge in the Mortal Realm had been shattered into pieces, but here it was whole?

A strange feeling rose in Duncan’s heart as he kept walking. After only a few steps, he suddenly stopped.

In the hazy depths of the cabin ahead, an old, heavy door stood alone.

Duncan felt his heart suddenly speed up, then hurried forward. The door’s shape came clearly into view.

It was exactly the same as the door in the bilge of the Vanished in the Mortal Realm!

Duncan came up to the door and noticed at once that it stood slightly open —a narrow gap leading inward.

Through that gap he could just make out what lay beyond.

It was a shattered cabin. Faint light floated inside it.

Duncan turned his head sharply and looked at where he stood.

An ancient, damaged cabin, dim and full of dust, abandoned for who knew how long—just like what he had seen through the crack of that door when he and Alice had once explored the Vanished’s bilge.

At last Duncan confirmed the guess he had held from the very beginning—

This place was on the other side of the door.

Chapter 242: Zhou Ming

He was now on the “other side” of the door.

After he confirmed this, Duncan could not help moving closer to the crack of the door, carefully watching the scene on the other side.

It made him think of what had happened after he explored the bottom hold last time. Back then he had rushed straight back to his studio apartment to check what was beyond the crack of the door. The same state of mind, the same scene.

But just like last time, there was not another “Duncan” on the other side, thrusting a sword this way.

Duncan frowned slightly.

He was now on this side of the door and had seen with his own eyes how things were here. He had even searched the whole ship, and during the search he had not found anything wrong.

Then what exactly was that thing he had seen through the crack of the door at the bottom of the ship in the Mortal Realm, the thing that had tried to disguise itself as him?

Duncan frowned again and turned to look around the empty, dim cabin. It seemed he wanted to find here the thing that had once disguised itself as “Zhou Ming”. He remembered that back then he had thrust his sword at what was beyond the crack. But if this really was Subspace on this side,

such a simple strike should not have been enough to kill the other party. There should at least have been some trace left behind.

However, there was nothing. No trace at all.

After searching carefully once more, Duncan finally began to doubt his judgment back then.

What he had seen through the crack of the door might have been only an illusion shown by Subspace, a phantom that only he at that moment could see. That fit the trait that “Subspace showed reflections of the mind”.

Except this still could not explain why that phantom had not affected his mind in the slightest, and why he had been able to deal with it so easily.

Duncan shook his head lightly and put these doubts aside for the time being. He could not help feeling a bit of emotion in his heart. Subspace really was a place full of mysteries.

Then his gaze returned to the door.

On this side, the door was open a little inward into the frame. At the bottom of the Vanished in the Mortal Realm, that door was open a crack outward. The two states matched each other.

On the other side was the world of the Mortal Realm, that familiar ship, the Vanished.

It seemed he had found the passage on this ship that linked Subspace and the Mortal Realm. In theory, if he pushed the door open here and stepped out, he should be able to return to the Mortal Realm.

Duncan put his hand on the doorknob, and a faint smile appeared on his face.

Then he gave it a gentle pull and closed the door.

It was surprisingly easy. He remembered that when he and Alice saw this door in the Mortal Realm, they had tried to close it. They had found that the whole door seemed cast into the very space, so solid that no matter how hard they pushed, it did not move at all. Yet on this side of the door, closing it only took a light pull.

With a small click, the door shut tight. Duncan quietly let his gaze rest on the now closed door. Only after a few seconds did his expression tense for a moment, then slowly relax. His heart seemed to react half a beat late and only now suddenly began to pound.

During those two seconds of closing the door, he had emptied his mind and thought of nothing. He had not thought about returning to the Mortal Realm, had not thought about being trapped here, had not thought about any consequences. He had only given himself one strong hint: “This door is dangerous.” Then he carried out the action without a moment of hesitation. Only after the door closed completely did he allow the emotions he had forced down to surge up, and he let out a long breath.

This might truly be an “exit” that connected to the Mortal Realm, but he must never really push this door open.

He had no clear proof, but a strong instinct kept warning Duncan that the way back to the Mortal Realm was definitely not as simple as pushing this door open from here. This was a lure, a trap. He had already gone through one lure in the lowest hold of the Vanished in the Mortal Realm. This was the second time, more hidden than the first and even harder to guard against.

Duncan’s eyes grew deep as he fixed his gaze on the door. Then he swept the blade in his hand, which burned with spirit form flame, across the door panel. ghostly green flame leaped up and almost at once engulfed the entire

door. Yet after a fierce burst of burning, the door still stood there quietly, as if it had not been affected at all.

Duncan slowly furrowed his brows.

Facing something that clearly belonged to the supernatural realm, his spirit form flame had failed for the first time. Yet it was not because this door was extremely solid. On the contrary, from the feedback of the flame he had not felt any resistance at all.

He had not even felt the door's existence.

Just like this ship, in his senses the door did not exist.

Yet this door could not possibly be nonexistent. Even if the ship really did "not exist", the door still had to exist. It could even put on him such a complex influence as "luring him to open it" and clearly held supernatural power. Something like that absolutely existed here.

Great confusion filled his head, and Duncan found it hard to sort out his thoughts. He checked around this door again and searched the entire cabin, but found no clue that could answer his questions. As time slowly passed, he could only give up for now.

He could not waste all his time in this strange place. Since this "exit" at the bottom hold carried great hidden danger, he should look for another way out.

While he was thinking, something suddenly came to Duncan's mind.

He turned at once and walked toward the stairs that led to the upper cabins. He hurried through the dark, empty cargo hold and the crew member quarters higher up, went through the gloomy wooden door that connected the upper deck and the cabin, and came out onto the deck.

The old, broken Vanished still drifted in chaotic darkness like outer space. From time to time, currents of tangled light and shadow around it lit up the huge, terrifying Shadows of floating fragments that drifted past at different distances. Some of those fragments looked like shattered land. Some looked like huge twisted creatures. Some could not be recognized at all, only heaps of pure “debris” that had already lost all color and shape. They were horrible to look at.

But Duncan did not focus on those giant floating things. He walked straight across the empty deck and returned to the door of the captain’s cabin.

The door of the captain’s cabin stood quietly there, just as it had when he left.

Duncan lifted his gaze. On the doorframe, in the dim light, he could faintly see several familiar words.

The Door of the Lost Ones.

Sure enough, just as he had expected, the special mark on this door was still there.

Duncan steadied himself and put his hand on the doorknob.

If there was anything on this ship that meant the most to him, this door came first.

This door connected to everything he was familiar with. It had also brought him his first and greatest mystery in this world.

Duncan applied a little force and pushed the door inward. With a soft creak of the hinges, the Door of the Lost Ones opened easily, just as he remembered. On the other side of the door was the thick fog he knew so well.

After a short hesitation, Duncan stepped forward.

The feeling of passing through dense fog rushed over him. Then came a brief sense of weightlessness and chaotic dizziness. Very soon it all faded away, and Zhou Ming slowly opened his eyes.

He did not return to the studio apartment he had lived in for so long.

He was standing in darkness.

Zhou Ming lowered his head and saw that he indeed had the body he once had as an “Earth human”. Then he turned around and saw the door he had come through standing quietly there. It stood in the darkness without any support, still open.

When he looked around, he saw only endless darkness. It was an extremely pure black, as if all things had died and as if the universe itself no longer existed.

Zhou Ming quickly summed up a new piece of experience. On the “old and broken Vanished”, pushing open the Door of the Lost Ones did not send him back to his familiar studio apartment. It led into a strange, pitch-black space.

Such an extreme darkness was enough to make an ordinary person feel huge pressure and even fear. Zhou Ming knew this. Yet for some reason, he felt no resistance while standing here. Instead, he felt a strange and inexplicable relaxation and ease.

He did not know where this eerie feeling of relaxation came from. But in his mind he knew his state was not quite right. The conflict between reason and his senses made him even more cautious, and he tried taking a step forward.

Even though everything here was black and seemed empty, there was ground beneath his feet. When he stepped out, he still felt the solid sensation of stepping on something real.

Zhou Ming lowered his head and looked at the place where his foot had landed. At that moment he suddenly saw faint ripples spreading out under his feet. In this pitch-black place, something other than darkness appeared. Inside the ripples, words emerged.

Chinese characters he knew well.

“His age?”

“Around thirty five.”

There were just these two lines of words. They looked like a question and an answer.

Zhou Ming’s expression changed slightly. Then he tried stepping forward again. Sure enough, the instant his foot landed, new ripples appeared in the darkness. They were still Chinese, still a pair of question and answer.

“His occupation?”

“A middle school teacher in language and literature, who liked to read in his spare time.”

Zhou Ming felt his heart pounding. He changed direction without thinking and took another step in the darkness.

“His height?”

“Around one meter eighty. He is not very strong, but in good health.”

Zhou Ming stopped and quietly watched the ripples under his feet spread. The gray white Chinese characters within them became clearer and clearer, then faded and disappeared as the ripples spread out.

He did not know how long he stood there before he finally took a deep breath and stepped forward again, slowly but firmly.

Words rippled out with his step.

“What does he look like?”

“Like this.”

In the darkness, a sudden light appeared. Something seemed to condense into shape in that light. Zhou Ming suddenly saw a figure appear before him, a figure exactly the same as himself.

His heart almost skipped a beat, and he stepped back half a pace without thinking. That backward movement made him realize that what stood before him was actually a mirror.

The figure was his reflection in the mirror.

Then he lowered his head and looked at the new ripples caused by his half step back. In the ripples, words appeared.

“His name?”

“Zhou Ming.”

Chapter 243: Return

Zhou Ming stood in front of the mirror, quietly letting his gaze rest on his reflection.

The mirror world was so clear and so real that if he had not reached out and touched a cold, hard surface, he would have suspected that another self was truly standing opposite him.

After a long time, he finally drew his gaze away from the mirror and looked at the vast darkness around him.

How big was this space? If he kept walking outward, could he walk to infinity? What was the nature of this dark space? Why did it appear here, behind the Door of the Lost Ones? What connection was there between this Door of the Lost Ones in Subspace and the Door of the Lost Ones in the Mortal Realm? And, most important of all…

What were those words that appeared in the darkness?

Zhou Ming walked away from the mirror. As he left, the mirror quietly faded, and the figure within it vanished into the darkness. With his steps, more pale words appeared in the dark, describing everything about him.

They were like an extremely detailed personal file, a dossier recorded in some crucial database, though he had no idea what it would be used for.

Zhou Ming felt that even his power of imagination was not enough. He tried to find a reasonable explanation for what he saw, but no matter how he reasoned, in the end it all looked like wild fantasy.

He even started to feel that there might be a “Doomsday shelter plan”, and he was someone who had hidden in the shelter without knowing it. That studio apartment was his protective fortress, and the words appearing in this dark space were the registration dossier he had filled out before entering the shelter…

In the darkness, his thoughts flowed out of control. But after an unknown time, he suddenly gathered up all his wild ideas.

“…I have wasted enough time.”

He muttered the words softly.

There were no more clues here, only phantoms that could shake his mind. Whether this dark space really hid a huge secret, or whether it was just another scheme and lure from Subspace aimed at him, he should not stay here and get lost in it.

Zhou Ming took a slow breath and let his mood gradually calm. Then he decided to run one last test and one last exploration in this dark space before he left.

He walked toward the distance, cautiously and carefully moving away from the door.

More words appeared under his feet. Their content was similar to before, but more detailed and more formal, more and more like registration data used in an official setting.

As Zhou Ming silently memorized these words, he kept turning his head from time to time to confirm his distance from the door and to make sure he had not lost his sense of direction in the darkness.

He grew more and more cautious as he walked. In the end, each step moved him forward only a dozen centimeters.

Suddenly, he noticed a change in the words appearing under his feet.

“The situation of ?#%… whether % @#?”

“?@* was probably between 355 and *&, and there might be &…% of %&…”

The words began to grow messy. The sentences became strange and hard to understand. The once clear and smooth records turned into something he could hardly read at all.

Something stirred in Zhou Ming’s heart, but he did not stop moving forward. He only walked even more carefully. As he kept going toward the edge of the darkness, more words surfaced in the dark.

They became stranger and more chaotic, and the confusion grew at an exponential rate. At first he could still see a few meaningful words in each sentence, but soon it reached the point where several sentences did not contain a single readable character. After that, he could not even see the “nonsense symbols” anymore.

What emerged from the darkness was no longer words and symbols, but a series of twisted, leaping lines, restless points of light, and even trembling projections that seemed to almost break the rules of geometry.

As he walked forward, chaotic lights and shadows that a mortal mind could hardly understand appeared in the darkness. They looked like unspeakable reflections at the edge of the universe and turned into a path that stretched out under his feet.

At last, even the chaotic lines and jumping points of light disappeared. Nothing new appeared.

Zhou Ming stopped at once.

He had not yet lost his reason. He had not become obsessed with the constant search toward the unknown.

He looked back. The door he had come through had almost shrunk to a hazy point of light, but it still stood quietly in the darkness.

Zhou Ming turned around decisively and started back. No matter what else lay deeper in the darkness, the moment the information beneath his feet came to an end, he knew he could not go any farther.

He walked back faster than he had come. It did not take long for him to cross that empty darkness and return to the Door of the Lost Ones that led to the Vanished.

When he laid his hand on the door, the solid touch gave Zhou Ming, who had been wandering and exploring in the darkness for a long time, a strange sense of steadiness. Then he took a light breath and stepped through the door.

A slightly cool sea breeze blew against his face. The bright daylight that suddenly filled his vision made Duncan a little uncomfortable for a moment. The faint rocking under his feet and the sound of waves crashing at his ears reached his senses a fraction of a second later. Perhaps he had stayed too long in a place of total silence, because when the sound of the waves appeared, it felt almost like thunder.

Duncan suddenly froze.

He checked his surroundings and saw the familiar Vanished, the familiar Boundless Sea, and the Sun hanging in the sky, bound by double layers of runes.

He had returned to the Mortal Realm.

This unexpected situation left him a bit dazed. Just a second before he stepped through the door in that darkness, he had still been thinking about

how to keep exploring the “broken Vanished” to find a way back. He had not thought that going through the door from there would send him straight back to the Mortal Realm. What was the rule behind this?

To return from that “broken Vanished”, which seemed to be in Subspace, to the Mortal Realm, did he only need to use the Door of the Lost Ones as a transfer point?

He turned around thoughtfully and saw that he was standing before the captain’s cabin. The Door of the Lost Ones stood quietly in the sunlight, and the words on its frame shone in the bright sky.

Duncan’s thoughts suddenly became very active.

There were many doors on the Vanished, but only three were special. The first was the Door of the Lost Ones. The second was the gloomy wooden door deep in the cabin that led to the lowest hold, marked with the words “The Last Door”. The third was the door standing in midair at the center of the lowest hold, which connected Subspace and the Mortal Realm and could perhaps be called the “Door of Subspace”.

Yet on the “broken Vanished”, both the Last Door that led to the lowest hold and the Door of Subspace had the marks on their frames wiped away. Only the Door of the Lost Ones in front of the captain’s cabin kept the exact same appearance in both the Mortal Realm and Subspace.

Now it seemed that this “consistency” might have pointed to the true “exit” from the very beginning.

With a faint answer forming in his heart, Duncan let out a breath, then stepped forward and pushed open the door of the captain’s cabin.

After he crossed the threshold, he confirmed that there was no darkness on the other side, but his studio apartment. Everything in the room was normal.

Then he returned to the ship again and, this time, pulled open the door of the captain's cabin.

There was the familiar enchanted sea chart room, the familiar tasteful furnishings, the familiar table, and on the table, the familiar Goathead.

For the first time in his life, seeing Goathead still resting properly on the table gave him a sense of reassurance.

As soon as Goathead heard the sound at the door, it turned its head at once. A creaking noise of wood rubbing on wood came from its neck as it asked: "Name?"

"Duncan Abnomar. It's me, I'm back," Duncan said at once. He had already guessed that the other party would ask for confirmation. This Goathead could sense whether he had left the Vanished and might even sense certain "changes" in him to some extent. Its "name checks" seemed random on the surface, but there was a faint pattern to them. "I went very far away."

"Ah, Captain, you finally came back!" Goathead cried in an exaggerated and eager voice. It was as noisy as always. "You suddenly left the ship completely, and you really scared me! When you walk in the Spirit Realm, at least you leave your body here. But just now all your presence disappeared… and now you are coming back from the deck? Where did you go?"

All presence gone? Completely left the ship?

Duncan's eyes changed slightly for a moment.

So he really had entered that place that was likely Subspace with his true body, not with the "projection of consciousness" he had first assumed.

He raised his head and looked into Goathead's pitch black eyes. After a slight hesitation, he said: "Don't be scared when you hear this."

“Ah, do not worry. Your First Mate is not only loyal and brave, but also brave and loy…”

“I went to Subspace.”

Goathead: “…?!”

It took a full half minute before the thing suddenly let out a cracking sound, its neck almost twisting off, as it cried: “Cap… Cap… Captain? You said you…”

“I went to Subspace, if I did not go to the wrong place,” Duncan said as he walked into the captain’s cabin and casually picked up the consecrated lantern from the nearby shelf. “Wait for me for a moment.”

Having said that, he did not wait for Goathead to speak. He grabbed the consecrated lantern and left the captain’s cabin, almost rushing through the deck and the layers of cabins straight toward the lowest level of the Vanished.

He passed through the Last Door and came to the shattered lowest hold.

Between the gaps in the hull at the bottom, everything still looked dim and chaotic. Within the limited field of view he could not see many details, only the turbulent currents of light and shadow and occasional flashes jumping and flowing in the darkness.

And the most dangerous Door of Subspace stood quietly at the center of the cabin.

The door was tightly shut, with not even a crack.

Chapter 244: A Corner of the Veil

Duncan walked up to the door and checked its state again, still not at ease.

The Subspace Gate really was closed now. He had indeed gone to the other side of the door before, and with that simple push over there, he had fully sealed this massive door that could hardly be shaken in the Mortal Realm.

He let out a soft breath and lifted his head to look above the door.

That line of mysterious, ancient script still stood out clearly on the frame: “This door leads to the Vanished.”

“Leads to the Vanished…” Duncan could not help recalling what lay beyond the door. He thought of that Vanished that sailed in Subspace, the ship that looked as if it had been abandoned and decaying for countless years. Suddenly he had a faint understanding of the words on the frame.

The words on this door were true. Beyond it really did lie the Vanished, another Vanished – the twisted projection, in Subspace, of the Vanished that existed in the Mortal Realm.

Duncan picked up the consecrated lantern, turned, and left the lower hold. Without stopping, he passed through the cargo hold and upper structures under the Inversion of light and shadow and returned to the captain’s cabin.

“Ah! Captain, you are back!” Goathead was still a bit dazed here. The first thing it did when it saw Duncan return was start nagging: “Why did you suddenly leave like that? Just now you said you went to Subspace? You cannot joke about that! You…”

“I closed the Subspace Gate in the bilge,” Duncan said casually as he put the consecrated lantern back in its place. “I just went down again to confirm it from this side.”

Goathead’s words stuck in its throat at once, and there was another sharp crack from where its head met the table.

Duncan could not help glancing at it: “Take it easy. Do not end up with the same problem as Alice.”

Goathead did not care about the teasing in the captain’s tone. It did not hide its shock at all: “You closed that door?! You mean… you closed it from the Subspace side?”

“What else?” Duncan asked back. “Isn’t that door impossible to close from this side? Why else would I go to all that trouble?”

“Y-you… just for that?” Goathead actually sounded a bit incoherent now. “You entered Subspace, then came back to the Mortal Realm, just so you could close that door from the other side? That… that is not some ordinary wooden door to a store room or junk closet, and you just… closed it like that?!”

Duncan’s mood suddenly improved.

He just stood there happily watching Goathead, watching this creature who usually nagged so much it could boil someone’s brain fall into a stammering mess. Goathead shook on the table like it had been put on vibrate, going crack, crack, crack the whole time. Duncan’s face stayed calm, but inside he was almost laughing himself sick.

Duncan knew he had not explained everything yet and that he had let Goathead misunderstand a few things. But mainly, he wanted to see this thing’s tongue get tied. This was the joy of the Boundless Sea’s number one troublemaker.

Along with that joy, the slight oppressive feeling brought on by exploring the ruined Vanished and that dark space also weakened a lot.

But in the end, Duncan still spoke up. After all, it was about Subspace. Some things had to be made clear to avoid risks later. And Goathead knew many hidden things; its knowledge might be useful.

“I know you are anxious, but don’t be. Let me finish first,” Duncan said. “I did close that door, but going into Subspace this time was an accident. I also need to hear what you think.”

“An… accident?” Goathead stiffened. Its tone shifted from shock to extreme seriousness in an instant. “Please, tell me. What exactly happened?”

Duncan told Goathead how he had fallen into a light sleep and, when he opened his eyes, had entered Subspace. Of course, he left out the details of his exploration in that pitch-black space, and focused on the door in the bilge and on the sights he saw when he looked out at the chaos from the deck.

After all, by now, other than his “true name” and “origin,” there was not much he needed to hide from Goathead anymore. And hiding his true name and origin was not so much because those secrets were especially important, but because the Vanished’s stability had to rest on this “anchor” called Captain Duncan.

Goathead listened to Duncan’s account in utter silence, taking it very seriously.

Then it said that it had no idea what was going on either…

“From what you described, that was indeed Subspace,” Goathead said frankly. “But I have never heard of something like this. You entered there directly in your sleep… and then came back safe and sound. You must

understand, even though Subspace is a grave threat to the Mortal Realm, that does not mean it is an easy place to reach. Its danger lies more in its corruption that seeps in without warning.

“Cracks in the mind, shaken faith, a wrong sacrificial rite – any of these can let the power of Subspace infiltrate. But ‘infiltration’ and going in like you did to ‘explore’ are completely different ideas.”

Here it paused, then turned its head. Its hollow black eye sockets stared straight at Duncan.

“Captain, are you sure you were not affected over there? You really… do not feel like anything was left in your head?”

“No,” Duncan spread his hands, utterly calm. “Do I look like I am out of my mind? I feel completely normal.”

Goathead suddenly had nothing to say.

Duncan spoke in a thoughtful tone: “You are always worried that the Vanished will fall into Subspace again. I actually thought falling in was easy…”

“That… is a relative idea,” Goathead explained with some difficulty. “Falling downward from the Mortal Realm is very dangerous, but even the Vanished will not ‘fall’ so easily. ‘It is dangerous if you fall’ and ‘it is easy to fall’ are not the same thing. And… how should I say this… in most cases, the unfortunates who plunge into Subspace… the process and feeling of them entering Subspace are completely different from yours. It is an extremely painful and terrifying process, and it often does not end simply with death…”

Duncan thought for a while after hearing this, then shook his head: “I really did not feel anything like that…”

Goathead held back for a long time, then finally let out a sigh.

Duncan was even a bit shocked. For the first time ever, this chatterbox did not say anything and only sighed!

Duncan thought about it and asked, very seriously: "…Should I be acting more serious?"

Goathead said: "…You truly live up to your title as the moving calamity of the Boundless Sea…"

It was completely flat, with no emotion at all, like it was reciting a line from muscle memory.

"Then let us drop this topic," Duncan said, waving his hand when he saw this, and he changed the subject at once. "What were those huge shadows I saw in Subspace? Those broken lands, the wreckage, and that pale one-eyed giant… what are they?"

Goathead suddenly fell silent. Almost half a minute passed before it slowly spoke: "As you saw… they are just wreckage."

"Just wreckage?" Duncan frowned. "That is not an answer. Wreckage of what? Where did it come from? From when? All of that…"

"Wreckage of worlds," Goathead said. "All those that did not live until today became twisted shadows in Subspace in the ancient past."

Duncan froze for a moment, then repeated in a low voice: "Wreckage of worlds?"

Goathead went silent again. It seemed to be hesitating, weighing something. In the end, it lifted its head slightly.

"Do you think the Boundless Sea is vast?" it asked. "Do you think… the Mortal Realm we live in now is still wide?"

Duncan blinked, then suddenly reacted: "You are saying… everything in the Mortal Realm now…"

“Yes. It is what was left over after the fall,” Goathead said softly. “A little bit of insignificant scum, with a few stubborn colonies clinging to it.”

Duncan stared, then suddenly thought of something: “Is this the truth behind the Great Annihilation?”

“It is only one tiny part of it,” Goathead said, its voice low. “The full truth of the Great Annihilation has been buried in the long river of time. There is no point trying to piece its whole shape back together.

“In your words, there is a ‘Horizon Limit’ there. All information lies on an unknowable, unseeable shore. Only if there were some truly all-knowing, all-powerful great being that could instantly grasp all secrets from Subspace to Abyssal Deep Sea, then to the Spirit Realm and the Mortal Realm, and then roll them back ten thousand years, could it know what exactly happened during the Great Annihilation – but what would be the point even then?

“I know what else you want to ask, but sadly this is all I know, and I cannot promise all of it is true. I do know some things related to Subspace, but even so-called ‘truth’ may already have been twisted into something else after Subspace’s influence. Cause and effect and the order of time have no meaning there. As for my own broken knowledge… even I do not know how much is real memory and how much is just shadows left over from the process of leaving Subspace.”

Chapter 245: A Serious Problem

Duncan fell into silent thought.

This was the first time Goathead had told him so many secrets about Subspace, and it was also the most open conversation the two of them had ever had.

Before today, Goathead had always shown huge resistance to anything about Subspace. It avoided the topic whenever it could and never answered Duncan's roundabout questions head-on. Back then, its attitude seemed not only to be about worrying over the Vanished's stability, but also about worrying over "Captain Duncan's" stability.

But today, its attitude had loosened – after the captain ran over to Subspace to close a door and then came back like nothing had happened.

It seemed it had finally relaxed enough to dare say what it knew.

Goathead said it did not know much and could not guarantee the truth of its information. But for Duncan, even the things it had just said were enough for him to mull over for a long time. They not only went beyond his current understanding of Subspace; they might even go beyond the research level of the scholars of the current civilized world.

After thinking for a long time, Duncan finally lifted his head. He looked at Goathead's eyes, deep in thought: "So you actually knew that much."

"I know a little, more or less… but I truly never meant to hide it from you," Goathead said. It even sounded a bit nervous. "For things related to

Subspace, the less you know the better, because many times knowledge itself is corruption. But now, it seems, the great Captain Duncan clearly does not need to worry about that…"

"I will take that as sincere praise," Duncan said casually. Then he looked Goathead up and down again, unwilling to let it go. "Is this really all you know? No more details? Like the identity of that pale one-eyed giant…"

"You are really making this hard for me," Goathead said helplessly. "To be honest, my memory… actually has some problems. A lot of things were forgotten 'over there'. What I have left now is only these rough impressions."

Duncan silently used his gaze, staring into Goathead's eyes. After a long time, he withdrew his gaze.

Goathead had indirectly admitted something else. It truly had not been one of the original "crew" of this ship. It had come from "the other side," from Subspace.

Was it that, when the Vanished broke away from Subspace, it "brought" something out with it, and that something later became Goathead? Or had Goathead deliberately hitched a ride and escaped from Subspace? Was it a deal?

For some reason, the image of that pale giant who had died at the edge of a celestial fragment rose again in Duncan's mind.

Subspace was packed with the wreckage left after the Old World shattered, but those things seemed to be more than just wreckage. Goathead seemed to have come from Subspace, yet it had reason and thought and could even talk. So, were there others like it in Subspace? Or… if it went back to Subspace, would Goathead become something else, something… like that pale giant? Was that why it resisted "going back" so much?

Many questions rose in Duncan’s mind all at once, but in the end he did not ask them outright.

Because he knew that when questions pointed directly at Goathead itself, and might also point toward “Captain Duncan,” the other side would never answer. It involved the stability of the Vanished in the Mortal Realm.

So he let out a small breath and stood up, showing that this topic was over for now.

Bright sunlight came through the window and fell on the simple, classical furnishings of the captain’s cabin. It made the floating dust glow softly.

“I missed the sunrise today,” Duncan said suddenly. “Did the Sun rise as usual?”

“Yes, the Sun rose on time at dawn,” Goathead answered at once. “It seems yesterday’s delayed sunrise was just an accident. Vision 001 is still operating normally.”

“For something like Vision 001, once it has a problem even once, the fear will be carved into people’s hearts forever,” Duncan said with a slight shake of his head. “Those who noticed the ‘fifteen minutes’ will probably never greet sunrise as lightly as before. Wait… do you remember what time sunset was yesterday?”

“Sunset?” Goathead thought for a moment, then spoke, not very sure. “Sunset should have been on time. It wasn’t affected. Why are you asking… ah!”

“You figured it out,” Duncan said, pulling his gaze back from the window. “Yesterday the Sun delayed sunrise by fifteen minutes, yet it set on time. That shows one thing.”

“It crossed the sky faster than usual yesterday…” Goathead finally reacted. “Vision 001… can consciously adjust how it operates?”

“At least yesterday it deliberately sped up to make sure it carried out ‘sunset’ at the correct time,” Duncan said in a low voice.

Goathead’s tone was a bit hesitant: “Then is that… good news? It means Vision 001 has some self-repair ability. Even if it has a small fault, it is still consciously making sure the world runs smoothly…”

Duncan did not answer.

Goathead seemed optimistic, but Duncan did not relax at all because of Vision 001’s “self-adjustment.” Instead, after confirming that the Sun had actively sped up for a day, he felt even more tense.

Because he knew a simple truth. When a vast, ancient, and unattended system suddenly starts using its reserve resources to repair itself, it often does not mean that the problem will be solved. It is a sign that the problems have piled up to a dangerous limit.

Duncan could not help walking to the window. He pushed it open all the way, leaned out, and looked up at the huge glowing orb shining down on the world, and at the two rings of runes that circled the glowing orb.

The light from Vision 001 was very bright but not blinding. Duncan could even just barely look straight at it.

But all at once, his gaze froze.

He stared hard at the Sun, at the runes on the edge of that ancient Vision. He studied them carefully and finally confirmed that he was not seeing things.

On the outer ring of that double circle of runes, hidden under the radiance, there was a slightly dimmer spot. If you looked closely, it was like a faint… gap.

…

In Pland, inside the antique shop, Duncan sat behind the counter, watching over Shirley, Alice, and Dog as they copied letters. Suddenly he lifted his head. Under the surprised stares of his three students, he walked quickly out of the shop and onto the open space in front, then tilted his head back to gaze up at the sky.

After a long time, until this fragile human body felt dizzy and his eyes were swimming, Duncan finally closed his eyes and lowered his head.

Nina, who had been helping teach Shirley and the others to read, ran out in worry: “Uncle Duncan, what is wrong?”

Duncan raised his head and gently ruffled Nina’s hair.

“Nothing. I just came out to look at the weather.”

“Look at the weather?” Nina looked up in confusion at the clear sky. “You could just look out the window from inside the shop. It is such a sunny day… ah, is something going to happen again?”

As she spoke, Nina suddenly lowered her voice and leaned close, grabbing Duncan’s sleeve like a little conspirator: “Did you think of something on the ship? Are we going on an adventure?”

“Adventure, adventure. There is not that much danger lying around,” Duncan said, half laughing, as he glanced at this young lady who had been dreaming of an “exciting new life” ever since she learned about the Vanished. “Stop wishing the world would fall into chaos. Isn’t a peaceful world nice?”

Nina stuck out her tongue in embarrassment. At the doorway, Shirley, who had slipped over out of curiosity to see what was happening, went a bit blank after hearing Duncan’s words. She stared for a while, then turned to whisper to Dog, who was hiding in the shadows: “The captain says he likes world peace.”

Dog did not react at all.

Shirley frowned and repeated herself. Then, from an angle hidden by the doorframe, she gave a little tug to the chain fused into her arm: “Dog, did you not hear me?”

Dog’s voice finally came from the shadows: “I am reciting the alphabet. Do not bother me while I am studying.”

Shirley: “…You really got into it?!”

“Of course. Mr. Duncan is going to check the homework later… even Miss Alice is more serious than you are!”

Shirley froze: “Homework? What homework?”

But Dog did not answer.

Because Duncan was already coming back to the doorway with Nina, and Shirley’s last mutter had landed right in his ears.

“Homework is the thing that will make me quite angry if you do not do it,” Duncan said, smiling as he looked at Shirley, whose whole body suddenly went stiff. “Copy the alphabet ten times when you go back.”

Shirley was about to cry: “Th-then you could just hit me instead…”

“Really?”

Shirley jolted upright: “No, no, I will go copy the alphabet right now!”

Duncan shook his head. He told Shirley, Dog, and Alice to study on their own for now and asked Nina to supervise them. Then, after one last look at the sky outside, he stood by the shop window and sank into thought.

Vision 001… really had a serious problem.

Chapter 246: Warm Days

Ever since the ancient kingdom of Critt vanished, Vision-001 had risen from the Sea of Blood, taking the place of the Sun of the Old Era and shining upon this world in the age of the Deep Sea.

For ten thousand years, this huge luminous core ran as if it were eternal. It not only brought light and heat to the world, but also gave daytime its stable order. Without it, there would be no city-state civilization as it now existed. The entire world would have been shrouded in terrible Eternal Night, and the mortal beings who had lost the protection of the ancient kingdom of Critt would probably have faded away in some distant age without a sound.

No one ever thought that Vision-001 would one day go wrong, just as no one ever stopped to wonder whether the Boundless Sea might someday dry up.

Yet now it seemed that this “eternal” Sun was not truly eternal.

First, sunrise was delayed by fifteen minutes. Then, a tiny gap appeared on the rune rings, almost too small for the naked eye to see. All these unsettling signs pointed to one thing: the lifespan of Vision-001 was actually limited.

Duncan stood beside the shop window, silently watching the bright daylight spill over the street, while his tangled thoughts churned like a storm.

He knew he was not the only one to notice the Sun’s abnormality. There were many clever people in the world. An ordinary person might not pay attention to the changes above their head, but in every city-state, within the

authorities and the Church, there were certainly people watching the world's greatest Vision at all times. By now, someone must have noticed the changes in the Sun. What would they think? How would they respond? Did anyone know what had really happened?

He also thought of those deranged Suntists, the ones who worshiped the ancient, true Sun. They spent all day muttering that Vision-001 in the sky was a sinful "False Sun," and that the Sun would one day fall. Did they know the Sun really was having problems?

Or were the changes in Vision-001 actually related to those Suntists and the Sun-spawn behind them?

To be fair, Duncan did not think much of those Suntists. In his eyes, whether it was an ordinary cultist or a somewhat stronger Sun-spawn, they were all about the same—ready to explode at the slightest spark. But the great fire in the city-state of Pland had reminded him that while ordinary cultists might not amount to much, the "Creeping Sun Wheel" behind them held a very high rank. On top of that, there was the group of elusive Enders stirring up the waters, and bizarre, insidious things like historical corruption and Mortal Realm overlays that no one could easily guard against. Who could say for sure that those Suntists did not have the ability to affect the operation of Vision-001?

Duncan let his thoughts wander for a long time and finally decided that he still needed to get in touch with Vanna when he had the chance. She was a high-ranking member of the Church and should be very clear about the Church's movements. He could discuss the matter of the Sun with her.

At the same time, he could show a bit of goodwill and prove that he cared about public security in the city-state.

Of course, next time he went over, he had to remember to knock.

Thinking this, Duncan split off a portion of his attention to check on the situation at the great Cathedral. Then he suddenly froze.

He sensed that Tyrian had left the great Cathedral and was moving toward the southern part of the Upper City.

After roughly confirming Tyrian’s direction, Duncan frowned slightly.

He thought of another part of his plan.

After a brief moment of thought, he raised his head and looked toward the counter.

Alice was leaning over next to Shirley, gripping a pencil and writing very, very seriously in a notebook of blank white paper.

Bright sunlight was shining through the antique shop’s glass window, slipping past the old-fashioned displays on the shelves to pour into the shop. sunlight fell on the golden-haired doll’s shoulders, as if coating Alice in a warm, gentle glow. sunlight also fell on the counter and the doll’s pen tip, giving the entire scene an indescribable softness and hint of mystery.

If this had been an oil painting, it would have needed a name—something like: A Beautiful Doll Writing Quietly in the Warm Afternoon sunlight.

Even Duncan was a little dazed by this perfectly timed play of light and shadow. He walked over and glanced down, and saw that Alice was earnestly copying some letter or another. Who knew where she had started writing it wrong; by now, the entire sheet was covered with little circles packed together into a solid mass.

Noticing the captain coming close, Alice immediately stopped. She happily held up the notebook to show Duncan: “Mr. Duncan, look at what I wrote~”

Duncan: “…”

He held back for a long moment, looking at Alice's simple, joyful smile, with the image of that oil painting still lingering in his mind. In the end, he could not bring himself to voice his doubts. He only managed to keep his face straight and give a stiff nod: "There… is progress."

Even though he could not tell what it was supposed to be.

Alice was delighted. It seemed she needed only that single bit of praise. Then she looked into Duncan's eyes with curiosity: "Do you have something for me to do?"

Duncan was taken aback: "How did you know I had something I wanted you to do?"

"You always look like this when you have something for me," Alice said, gesturing at her own face. She seemed to be trying to imitate Duncan's expression just now, though no one could really understand her performance. "What do you want me to do?"

"You're going to a place, together with AI," Duncan said as he put his expression in order. Looking at Alice's carefree smile, he thought of what he was about to do, and his mood unknowingly grew much lighter. "Bring someone here."

"Bring… them here?" Alice looked completely puzzled. "What does 'bring' them here mean? Do I need to knock them out and tie them up?"

"Where did you even learn that?!" Duncan immediately glared at the doll. "Come with me, I'll tell you what to do…"

…

Compared to a hundred years ago, the city really had changed a great deal.

Electric lines, new models of gas street lamps, smoother and wider roads, taller buildings, and countless factories and pipes. Scholars and engineers

had brought a power that could push civilization forward, and that power had made the city-states change at a speed far beyond the past. This change even made Tyrian, who had seen many storms in his life, feel a natural sense of amazement.

But in this city-state, some things still faintly resembled what he remembered.

After getting out of the car and thanking and taking his leave of the Church staff who had accompanied him, Tyrian walked along the streets on the edge of Pland's Upper City with several sailors he had brought from the Sea Mist. Looking at the roads and shops on both sides, strange yet somewhat familiar, he could not help the hint of nostalgia on his face.

"Captain," one sailor asked curiously, looking at his boss, "what are we here to find?"

"A shop," Tyrian said casually, his gaze searching among the street-front buildings that carried a strong Central City-States style. "A doll shop. The sign has a bit of an elves' style."

"A doll shop?" The sailor sounded a little shocked. "I didn't know you were into that."

Tyrian gave his subordinate a silent look. "I have my reasons."

Another sailor hurried over when he saw this: "Captain, maybe you should silence him first… If you're worried, you can silence all of us. After you finish browsing, you can clean us up however you like…"

"…I'm starting to regret bringing you lot."

The sailors burst into giggles, but while they joked, their eyes kept sweeping over the nearby buildings, searching for the shop that matched the captain's description.

Tyrian only shook his head, looking at the subordinates he had brought with a hint of helplessness.

Outside of battle, this was how he and his subordinates always interacted. Most people could never imagine that the legendary “Iron Vice Admiral” would be so easygoing among his own men. But Tyrian knew very well why.

These people had followed him through life and death for half a century. In the mortal world, there was no bond stronger than a loyalty and trust that had lasted fifty years.

Just then, a sailor’s voice suddenly came from the side, interrupting Tyrian’s thoughts.

“Captain, look, is it that one? That ‘Doll Gallery’ across the street… the name’s pretty unique.”

Tyrian looked up and at once saw a familiar line of words among the old street-front shops: Rose Doll House.

The sign had changed, the front door had changed, and even the facade had been redone, but the shop’s name was the same as ever. Elves were sentimental. Even when they lived in human city-states that changed at a frantic pace, they rarely changed the names of their shops lightly.

Tyrian suddenly felt a little dazed. Faded memories rose in his heart. He seemed to see that afternoon long, long ago, when his father went to the harbor on business and he took his young little sister and slipped out of the house. The two siblings wandered through the bustling great city-state until they stumbled, all mixed up, into that shop…

Then they briskly spent all the small change they had stolen from their father’s cash box. His little sister had a whole day of happiness, and he could no longer remember whether he had been beaten afterward.

No matter what, in Tyrian’s century-long stretch of cold memories, it was one of the few fragments that glowed with simple warmth.

“That’s the one,” the pirate lord said softly. “‘Doll Gallery’ is an elves-style name. It just means a doll shop.”

With that, he stepped toward the shop that seemed to occupy a special corner in his memories.

Chapter 247: Returning to an Old Place

A clear chime rang with the opening of the door. Afternoon sunlight fell into the old shop that was almost completely filled with all kinds of dolls. Behind the counter, an elven shopkeeper who had been carefully adjusting a doll's frame heard the sound and looked up. She saw a tall, black-haired man with an eyepatch over one eye stepping into the shop.

The elf old woman looked at this guest with some puzzlement. No matter how she looked at him, he did not seem like the type who came to buy dolls. But after a moment of confusion, she still smiled and greeted him. She simply did not recognize that this tall, one-eyed man was the same child who had brought his little sister to her shop to buy something a century earlier: "Ah, welcome to the Rose Doll House. Feel free to look around."

Then she paused for a second and added casually: "A guest like you is not very common."

Tyrian slowly let his gaze travel around the shop.

All kinds of dolls. Shelves and a carved staircase that both looked quite old. A warm, calm atmosphere, and the smiling old woman.

The faded pieces of memory gradually fit together, becoming familiar scenes and slowly overlapping with what he saw now.

This was definitely the place. Lucretia's directions had been right.

It was normal that the elven shopkeeper did not recognize him. Compared to a hundred years ago, he had changed far too much.

Tyrian adjusted his expression slightly, trying to make his face look a bit softer. Half a century of drifting and raiding on the Frost Sea had turned him into a man with a cold, hard face. He knew there was always an aura around him that made ordinary people uneasy, and that aura had clearly affected the kindly shopkeeper. She greeted him with a smile, but there was doubt and a little wariness in her eyes that she could not hide.

“I’d like to ask about something,” Tyrian said. He had no idea whether his expression adjustment had worked. He could hardly remember how an ordinary person was supposed to look and speak when walking into a shop. “Have you ever sold a doll called ‘Nilu’ here?”

He thought for a moment, then added two more lines: “A one-third-scale doll, about this tall—classical court style, with a very fancy dress.”

The elven shopkeeper froze for a second and answered with some hesitation: “We did… have a doll like that. It sat in the shop for many years, and someone bought it a little while ago. But why are you asking about it?”

“What kind of person bought it?” Tyrian felt his heartbeat speed up. He had not expected to find a lead so easily. His father really had gone and bought that doll openly from a shop. “About when was that?”

The old shopkeeper was clearly startled by Tyrian’s overly intense reaction and grew even more cautious. “I’m sorry, I can’t give out information about my customers. That’s a rule of our trade.”

Tyrian was stunned. He had not expected that answer. He thought quickly, hesitated for two or three seconds, as if he had made some decision, and then said: “…You didn’t recognize me?”

“Recognize… you?” The old shopkeeper frowned and looked him up and down with puzzled eyes. “I don’t remember serving any guest like you. Most of the people who buy dolls from me are women, or young men picking gifts for their lovers, or fathers picking gifts for their daughters.”

“That’s because the last time I was here was a very, very long time ago,” Tyrian said with a strange little smile. “Do you remember a pair of siblings who took away a doll called ‘Lunie’ from here a hundred years ago?”

The old shopkeeper froze for a moment, then slowly opened her eyes wide, staring at Tyrian in disbelief. “Ah, you’re…”

“I know you probably won’t believe me, but I have something that can prove who I am,” Tyrian said. His thoughts were moving quite fast. As he spoke, he reached into his coat and pulled something out. “Elves like you are well informed. You should have heard of me… take a look at this.”

The old elf woman took the piece of paper from him with a doubtful expression. When she opened it, she first saw a large portrait printed on it. Below that were the words of a wanted notice, the bounty, and the official mark of the city-state of Frostholm…

“I have a bit of a reputation,” Tyrian said very seriously. “Strictly speaking, my whole family is fairly well known… though maybe not in a pleasant way.”

The old shopkeeper: “…”

After a long moment, the elven old woman finally managed to control her expression. She looked up at Tyrian and, in a peculiar tone, forced out a line: “So it really is you.”

Tyrian also realized that something about this felt off, and he answered with an awkward smile: “It’s me.”

The old woman thought for a bit more. “So many years have passed… and there are that many zeros after your name now…”

Tyrian twitched the corner of his mouth. “The bounty… is a bit high. But it’s just for show. They add another zero every four or five years anyway. No one is ever going to collect it.”

“…You’re the first pirate lord I’ve ever met who carries his own wanted poster around and uses it as ID,” the elf old woman said. Her expression finally looked normal as she folded the wanted notice and handed it back while muttering, “I did hear that the Sea Mist had docked. I was thinking I’d go down to the harbor to watch the commotion when I had time. I didn’t expect you to show up first. How’s your little sister?”

“She… is living even more freely than I am,” Tyrian said. Then he gave the old woman another odd look. “I thought you’d be scared. That’s how most ordinary people react when they see me—even outside the Frost Sea.”

“I’ve seen plenty of strange things in my time. You’re not the only pirate lord out there. Besides, the city-state already issued a notice saying the Sea Mist is a guest invited by Pland. Whatever happened up in the Northern Seas has nothing to do with us,” the old woman muttered as she walked back toward the counter. Her muttering soon turned into nagging. “But I still have to say this, you know. Being a pirate forever is not proper work. It’s not a business you can keep doing, and it doesn’t sound good to others. Look at your little sister. At least she has a lifelong honorary title at the Explorer Association. Of course, I’ve heard your relationship with those northern city-states is quite complicated…”

Tyrian’s head started buzzing at once. He felt he had now truly experienced the calm and ease of a long-lived race, and he had to cut off the old woman’s lecture in a hurry: “The Sea Mist fleet is already changing.

Retaliation and raiding against the northern city-states are things of the past. These days we mostly rely on collecting protection fees…”

Before the old woman could react, he decisively ended that topic and dragged things back by force: “Can you tell me now who bought that doll?”

“Oh, it was a middle-aged man who looked about your height… maybe a bit shorter. He was quite thin, like his health wasn’t very good,” the old woman said without further fuss. “But I don’t think you’ll find him. There are so many people in Pland. Were you hoping to bring back the other doll you couldn’t buy back then for your little sister? Ah, that’s such a pity. If you’d come earlier… wait, I just realized—how did you know someone bought ‘Nilu’?”

Tyrian did not answer her question. He only frowned without thinking.

Someone shorter than him, slender, and in poor health… That could not be his father.

Could it have been one of his father’s subordinates?!

After regaining his humanity and sanity, had he already started picking out new subordinates? What was he planning? Was he trying to rebuild the Lost Home fleet?!

Tyrian’s thoughts raced in all directions. Only when the elf old woman called his name twice did he snap back to himself. Then something else came to mind, and he quickly asked: “Besides buying the doll, did that guest say anything else? Did he take anything else with him?”

“What did he say…? We just chatted a little, very normally,” the old shopkeeper said, thinking back. “He seemed like a guest who really liked dolls. He cared a lot about repairs and upkeep, and he learned quite a bit from me. Oh, right, he also bought a wig and matching hair accessories, which seemed to be for his own doll.”

Tyrian’s expression froze. “…A wig? What kind of wig?”

“Long, straight golden hair, full-size. I remember it quite clearly,” the old shopkeeper said. Then something else occurred to her. “Oh, and I still have one that’s almost the same. You can take a look.”

As she spoke, she had already turned around and slipped into the storage room under the stairs to search.

Tyrian wanted to say it was not necessary to go to the trouble, but he did not have time. Just then, a strange knocking sound came from nearby and drew his attention.

It sounded like someone knocking on the shop window.

Tyrian turned his head in surprise and looked toward the source of the sound.

He saw a beautiful lady with golden hair down to her waist standing outside, gently tapping on the glass.

At first, Tyrian did not react. But when he saw the lady’s face clearly, he went rigid on the spot as if struck by lightning.

That lady’s features… were exactly the same as Frostholm’s queen, Ray Nora, from half a century ago!

Chapter 248: The Invitation

The shopkeeper of the Rose Doll House had been rummaging in the storeroom for a long time before she finally found what she wanted. But when she squeezed back out, she saw that the “guest” who had been standing at the counter was already gone.

“…So impatient…” After she confirmed that Tyrian had left, the old woman could not help muttering, “No wonder the younger sister became a scholar, while the brother ran off to fight wars…”

Tyrian had no way of knowing what that elderly elf madam was grumbling about behind his back. By then, he had already rushed out of the doll shop and stepped onto the street outside.

He stood in the open space in front of the shop and looked around, but he still could not find any trace of that blonde lady.

The sailors who had stayed outside to wait saw their captain come out and look around. They hurried over and said: “Captain, we’re over here.”

“I wasn’t looking for you,” Tyrian said quickly, his eyes still sweeping the nearby streets and alleys. “Did any of you see a lady with long golden hair standing by the window just now? About… half a head shorter than me, wearing a purple dress.”

The sailors looked at one another. Then all of them turned to Tyrian with the exact same stunned expression.

Tyrian frowned: “…What is that look supposed to mean?”

“Captain…” One sailor gathered his courage and spoke, sounding hesitant. “Love at first sight is a good thing, but I think a romance that crosses city-states is…”

Tyrian looked calmly at his subordinate and said: “If you keep talking, I’ll stuff you into The Sea Mist’s six main guns one by one and fire you in six different directions.”

The sailor fell silent on the spot.

Tyrian had already started thinking quickly.

He was certain he had not seen wrong. Just now, outside the window, there really had been a blonde woman whose face was exactly the same as Her Majesty Ray Nora of Frostholm, knocking on the glass.

In a crowd, if it were only someone whose features were somewhat similar to the Queen of Frostholm, Tyrian would not have reacted much. Over a half-century of life, he had seen plenty of people with similar faces. But the woman knocking on the window was different.

She had obviously come for him.

A woman who looked almost exactly like the Queen of Frostholm appeared near this doll shop as if she had planned it, knocked on the window to draw his attention, and then ran off the moment he appeared. This whole chain of actions sent a very clear signal.

Tyrian frowned slightly. It felt as if something faint had flashed through his mind. He raised his head and looked at the men he had brought with him: “All of you, go back to the Cathedral first.”

“Huh?” The sailors froze. One of them spoke in surprise: “But…”

“No buts,” Tyrian waved his hand. “I have some things to deal with. You leave first.”

Another sailor still could not hold back and said: “But, Captain, the few of us…”

Tyrian’s expression turned serious: “That’s an order.”

“But we didn’t bring any money,” the third sailor finally finished his sentence. “We don’t even have enough for the carriage fare—getting from here to the Cathedral isn’t close.”

Tyrian: “…”

A moment later, the “Steel Vice Admiral” threw a pouch of small coins at his subordinates and almost ground the words out between his back teeth: “You lot, get lost.”

The sailors left. Tyrian finally let out a small breath of relief. He glanced around, thought for a moment, and then walked toward the quietest corner of an alley within sight, where he silently waited for the other party to appear.

If his guess was right, she would come out on her own. He had just dismissed the men he brought in order to send a clear signal that it was “safe to meet.”

And things went just as he expected.

He waited in that deserted alley for less than a moment before he suddenly heard footsteps nearby. He looked up toward the sound and saw the blonde lady with the Queen of Frostholm’s face stepping out of the shadows not far away.

Even though he had already seen her once through the shop window, Tyrian still could not help feeling shocked now—it was just too similar.

He had indeed seen people with similar faces before, but this degree of resemblance… already went far beyond common sense, beyond

imagination.

Precisely because of this extreme similarity, Tyrian's first reaction after that instant of shock was caution and wariness. He stared at the mysterious blonde lady as if she were a dangerous person who deserved his full attention. In that careful observation, he also noticed a few strange details.

Her movements carried an elegance and restraint that did not belong to an ordinary person. Her face was delicate and flawless, yet lacked a certain… "living breath." An ordinary person might not notice anything, but as a captain who commanded a legion of Living dead, Tyrian gradually sensed from her a trait that felt very wrong on a living being.

"Incredible," the blonde lady spoke just as Tyrian's wariness grew. "You actually came. So luring someone out is this easy."

Even her voice was exactly the same as the Queen of Frostholm's.

Tyrian felt no joy or excitement at all. Instead, he grew even more guarded: "…Who are you?"

"My name is Alice," the blonde lady said with a calm smile.

"…I'm not asking your name." Tyrian frowned. "I'm asking what you are, and what you intend to do. Why did you insist on meeting me?"

"Captain wants to see you," Alice answered very seriously, responding to his question point by point. "He said that while you stay in the Cathedral, there are too many people around, and it's hard to discuss many secret matters. So he had to lure you somewhere quieter so you could talk."

A mysterious captain wanted to talk about secret matters and sent someone to lure him out.

Tyrian frowned, but for some reason, he actually felt more relaxed inside. He had been a pirate on the Frost Sea for half a century. He had seen far too

many situations like this. Compared to Her Majesty Ray Nora of Frostholm suddenly coming back from the dead to look for him, a secret meeting and conspiracy between captains was what he was more used to.

But he still had no intention of going along with it.

“I’m not interested in people who hide their heads and show their tails,” Tyrian said casually once he recognized this “scene.” “Go tell your master this: if he wants to meet the captain of The Sea Mist, he can come openly and find me at the Cathedral. If it’s shady business he can’t show in the light, then sorry. Outside the Frost Sea, The Sea Mist only does legal work.”

When he finished speaking, he was ready to turn and leave. But the blonde lady who called herself Alice suddenly said: “You don’t want to know who I mean when I say ‘captain’?”

“Hmm?” Tyrian frowned. “Who?”

“Your dad,” Alice said honestly.

Tyrian’s expression changed at once: “Sorry, that joke is not funny at all. Excuse me.”

Alice thought for a moment and said: “Ah, Captain also said you might react like this, so he has another invitation plan…”

Tyrian was just about to turn and leave, but when he heard that, he instinctively hesitated: “Another…”

He had only muttered a couple of words when he suddenly felt the air around him change. A surge of warning rushed up inside him. He jerked his head toward the source of the feeling, and saw only a little girl standing there. He did not even know when she had appeared. She swung her arm in a wide arc and threw something at him.

It looked like a dog.

For less than a second, Tyrian felt he still had a chance to dodge. Even though the other side had launched a sneak attack, and even though that strength and speed were clearly extraordinary, he still felt he could avoid it. But in the same instant he tried to move, he found that all his limbs had stopped responding. It was as if countless invisible threads had wrapped tight around his bones and muscles. He lost control of his own body.

The only thing he managed to do was to barely turn his head and glance at the blonde lady, who was smiling harmlessly. In the next second, a hideous dog head swelled to fill the edge of his vision.

With a loud bang, the Pirate Lord flew several meters away and did not move again.

Shirley stared at the result, a little dazed.

"…He just went flying like that?" She looked at the chain in her hand, then at Tyrian, who had been smashed away. As she walked over to check on him, she muttered: "I thought there would at least be a fierce battle. So this is the legendary Pirate Lord… I didn't smash him to death, did I?"

"I don't think so," Alice also walked over. She looked at the unconscious Tyrian and muttered with Shirley: "Captain said Tyrian is a child who can take a beating."

"Why didn't he dodge just now?" Shirley squatted down, picked up a stick, and poked Tyrian's face. "Even those Enders earlier could dodge a few times at least…"

"I don't know," Alice shook her head. "I don't know how to fight."

Shirley thought for a moment and then had a new worry: "…If Captain sees his son's head swollen like this, will he be angry?"

"I don't think so," Alice shook her head again. "Captain said that if he doesn't cooperate, you should hit him with Dog and make him spin like a

top…”

“Did he spin just now?”

“I think… he did. He spun a lot of times in the air.”

Shirley finally relaxed and clapped her hands: “Then it’s fine. I’ll call AI over to move him.”

Chapter 249: The First Step Toward Honesty

Tyrian felt himself wrapped in darkness. In that darkness, his senses rose and fell. It was as if some invisible force was pulling him, carrying him through a dimension that lay between the Mortal Realm and illusion.

He tried several times to open his eyes, but could only see a faint green glow and shadows rushing past in the dark. After struggling to make sense of it, he realized that what he saw was a bird’s-eye view of the city-state below.

It seemed something was carrying him through the sky.

That single thought flashed through his mind, and he lost consciousness again.

When he could once more feel his body, he had already been placed somewhere stable. A cold, hard feeling came from beneath him, like a bare concrete floor. Dim light shone around him, like cheap bulbs used to light a warehouse. A blurry figure sat beside him, leaning closer as if looking at him curiously.

Tyrian’s mind finally cleared.

But he did not open his eyes at once. Instead, he kept pretending to be unconscious while carefully sensing his surroundings. He tried to judge where he was from the dampness in the air, the tiny sounds near his ears, and what little he could see through his barely opened eyelids.

He had just managed to hear a bit of faint traffic noise and had just confirmed that he might be in a building facing a street, when a voice he had heard right before blacking out suddenly sounded beside him. It was a voice that was all too familiar in his memory: “You’re awake. Your eyelids are moving.”

Tyrian’s heart lurched. He knew he had been found out, so he could only open his eyes helplessly.

Then his whole body stiffened. The person he saw left him shocked and at a loss.

He saw Ray Nora, Queen of Frostholm—exactly the same as in his memory, and not the blonde lady from before whose hair color had clearly been different.

The silver-haired “Queen of Frostholm” sat upright on a chair beside him. Her expression was calm and indifferent as she gazed at Tyrian lying on the floor. Tyrian stared blankly for several seconds before suddenly snapping to his senses and jerking himself upright.

A sudden wave of pain in his head almost knocked him back down, but the pain sharpened his mind, driving out the last bit of dizziness left from his fainting spell. First he confirmed that he was truly awake. Then he quickly looked around, trying to figure out where he was.

All he saw was a warehouse packed with shelves and wooden crates. High and low racks were crammed with old objects whose exact ages and origins were impossible to tell. The worn crates were piled in somewhat messy stacks along the walls. There were no windows in his field of view, so of course he could not see outside. The only door stood behind the chair where the “queen” was sitting.

It looked like just a warehouse. There was no way to judge where in the city-state it might be.

Tyrian's gaze came back and finally stopped on the "Queen of Frostholm."

But after that first wave of shock and excitement, the Pirate Lord's first true reaction, once he calmed down, was doubt. He thought of the blonde lady he had seen earlier and the things she had said. His brow furrowed: "You are not Her Majesty Ray Nora. Who are you really?"

"I said already, my name is Alice," the silver-haired woman on the chair answered with a smile. "Ah, if you mean my hair… I disguised it before. Captain said my real appearance might cause trouble in the city-state."

She mentioned the captain again.

The first time she had brought up this "captain," Tyrian had only felt a bit confused. Now, when he heard that title again, his first reaction was a strong sense of wariness and danger. He was sure this was not some bad joke, and not some stupid trap set up by a captain who hated him. Behind all of this, there really might be his terrifying father.

Tyrian slowly stood up. He watched the silver-haired woman who called herself Alice with full caution and said in a low voice: "Is it really him?"

"Yes. He has something to discuss with you," Alice said. She rose from the chair and walked to an antique mirror nearby. "Captain, he's awake."

In the next second, pale green flames rose along the edges of the mirror. Tyrian thought he heard a faint, unreal crackling sound. The mirror surface suddenly turned black, and a familiar, dignified figure slowly emerged from that darkness.

"Tyrian, we meet again," Duncan's voice came from inside the mirror.

“…Yes, we meet again,” Tyrian replied, hesitating. Even though they had already met once, speaking again with a clear-minded, rational father still made him feel extremely awkward. “Why did you use this method? I thought you didn’t mind contacting me in the Cathedral.”

“We can catch up in the Cathedral, but it’s not suitable for certain private topics,” Duncan said unhurriedly. His gaze swept past Alice. “There are some things I don’t intend to let Gamona listen in on. You’ve met Alice already. You should have a lot you want to ask.”

When Tyrian heard his father mention the Storm Goddess Gamona, a strange look crossed his face. But very soon, his attention was drawn back to Alice, whose face was exactly the same as the Queen of Frostholm’s. After frowning and thinking for a moment, he suddenly remembered something. His expression changed sharply: “Earlier, the Explorer Association sent a warning to all captains on the Boundless Sea. They said Anomaly 099 was out of control…”

“As you can see,” Duncan said with a smile, “she is standing right in front of you.”

Tyrian immediately gave Alice, who wore an innocent smile, a quick, startled glance, as if he had only now noticed the inhuman traits hidden within that overly perfect face, and the decorations on her body that clearly served to cover her joints. In the next heartbeat, he instinctively raised a hand to touch his own neck.

As one of the most experienced captains on the Boundless Sea, and as someone who paid close attention to any information related to the Queen of Frostholm, Tyrian knew very well what Anomaly 099 was like.

His movement did not escape Duncan’s eyes.

“Relax a little,” the voice from the mirror said. “Anomaly 099 is under control now.”

“…The doll in the container has awakened and is freely moving about outside, and you call that ‘under control’?” Tyrian kept a wary eye on Alice’s actions as he spoke to Duncan. At the same time, his neck felt cold. “How did you do it? How did you make an Anomaly with such a low number work for you, and even suppress her decapitation instinct?”

“Alice is a friendly doll. She isn’t as terrifying as people think—at least, not when she’s by my side,” Duncan said casually. “But you, I thought you would first bring up the Queen of Frostholm. As far as I know, you served by that queen’s side even longer than you served in the Vanished Fleet.”

Tyrian slowly realized what Duncan was getting at. He watched the figure in the mirror with wary eyes and said: “You want to learn things related to Her Majesty Ray Nora from me?”

“Do you feel resistant to that?” Duncan asked. “Do you not want to talk about it?”

“…I still don’t dare to fully believe in your ‘humanity,’” Tyrian said quietly.

Duncan was silent for a few seconds before he spoke again in a low voice: “Do you know what my first plan was?”

“Your first plan?”

“To have Alice disguise herself directly as Ray Nora, Queen of Frostholm,” Duncan said. “To pretend she had truly resurrected, or to act out a wraith projection, or even to step straight into your dreams—that would all be very easy for me.” Duncan met Tyrian’s eyes. “I could guarantee that you wouldn’t be able to tell truth from lies, and that, under mental guidance, you would say many things. I could easily get the information I wanted that way.”

A chill ran down Tyrian’s back.

He believed every word his father said. He believed that his father could indeed do these things, and he knew that he himself would definitely fall for it. Even if he noticed something off in some small detail, it would only be after he had already given away a great deal of information.

Because even just now, after already seeing the “blonde Alice” ahead of time and knowing that the person in front of him could not possibly be Ray Nora, he had still almost believed that this was truly the Queen of Frostholm resurrected.

Tyrian lowered his eyelids slightly without even thinking, as if this could keep his gaze from directly meeting his father’s. He asked in a low voice: “Then why didn’t you do it?”

Duncan gazed quietly at Tyrian.

Why else? Because Alice could not remember a script that long and could not act through a scene that complicated. The moment the other side tried to trick her with a random question, she would panic. And if she forgot her lines, she would, without a second thought, start shouting for help from her captain—save save save—seventeen saves in a single second.

She was useless to a degree that was hard to believe.

“Of course it’s because I don’t want to deal with my own children through deception—even though I’ve already forgotten many things,” Duncan said with a serious expression and a low voice.

Then he paused and added: “I also don’t want to use that kind of ‘farce’ to insult the sovereign you once served. Although I don’t know her well, from that brief ‘meeting once’ I had with her, Ray Nora seemed to be someone worthy of respect.”

“Clap clap clap clap—”

Hearing such a righteous answer from the captain, Alice immediately began to applaud. She had barely understood anything the captain had said.

Duncan and Tyrian both turned and stared at this doll with strange expressions.

“…Was I not supposed to clap?” Alice shrank her neck, peeking carefully at the captain in the mirror. “I just thought the captain was right…”

A wave of tiredness washed over Duncan. He sighed and said: “…As long as you’re happy.”

At the same time, Tyrian suddenly realized a small detail hidden in his father’s earlier words, and he was struck with shock:

“You met Her Majesty Ray Nora?!”

Chapter 250: Beneath the Surface

Tyrian took a few seconds to realize that Duncan had just mentioned a “brief encounter” with the Frostholm Queen. His shock showed plainly on his face.

Duncan was not surprised by this reaction. He only shook his head lightly and said: “My ‘meeting’ with her was very unusual. It did not happen on the normal timeline. You can think of it as me stepping into a crack in history and seeing Ray Nora once, as a bystander. In normal history, I never had any contact with the Frostholm Queen.”

Tyrian frowned, as if trying to understand what those difficult words meant. Then his eyes flickered. He drew back all his emotions, looked up at Duncan, and asked: “Why are you interested in the Frostholm Queen? Is it because of that ‘one meeting’? Or because of this Doll who calls herself ‘Alice’? Did she tell you something?”

“Alice doesn’t know anything about the Frostholm Queen. Her memory is as pure as blank paper,” Duncan said calmly. “I’m interested in the Frostholm Queen because everyone says the Frostholm rebellion back then happened because Ray Nora’s conspiracy with the Vanished was exposed. Don’t you think it’s quite normal for me to become curious after hearing that rumor?”

“…Colluding with the Vanished.” Tyrian’s voice was low, his eyelids lowered so no one could read his feelings. “Yes. That was the charge they pinned on Her Majesty Ray Nora.”

“Judging by your reaction, that charge really was a frame-up,” Duncan’s voice came from the mirror. “So the Frostholm rebellion back then was a complete conspiracy, and the crimes they gave Ray Nora were entirely made up?”

As he spoke, he watched Tyrian’s reaction.

But Tyrian did not answer at once. He frowned slightly and asked back: “Does this truth matter to you?”

“It does,” Duncan said, his face serious. “From a certain point of view, I am half an involved party.”

Tyrian clearly froze for a moment, as if unable to argue with Father’s answer. Then he sighed with a helpless smile and shook his head: “There really was a conspiracy behind that rebellion, but if I have to be strict about it, the name the Rebels used was not completely fake…”

“Oh?”

“The Frostholm Queen never colluded with the Vanished. But she did… carry out some research in forbidden fields. Once those research projects were made public, even without the rebellion, she probably would have had a hard time keeping her position as City Lord.”

Duncan’s eyes grew deep. After a few seconds of silence, he suddenly spoke: “It was called the ‘Abyssal Trench Project’, right?”

Tyrian jerked his head up in shock.

“I know much more than you think,” Duncan said quietly.

“But all data related to the Abyssal Trench Project has already been destroyed. Even the traitors who exposed it back then were purged and executed by the Rebels themselves…” Tyrian said in disbelief. “Everyone was convinced that even the name of the project itself had already been

tainted by the curse's corruption, and the last people who knew the truth all passed away long ago…"

"Oh? All the records were destroyed?" This time Duncan was the one who felt surprised. He had thought the matter might be highly classified, but he hadn't expected it to be buried this extremely. "Even every eyewitness is dead?"

Tyrian hesitated. He knew that time better than anyone, and of course he knew why the project was buried. After a brief silence, he still began to speak, slowly:

"This forbidden project was stained with too many things tied to the curse, Subspace, and mental corruption. Even the Rebels back then didn't dare speak lightly about the information they had found.

"But in fact, the name of this project was made public once, and only once. That was at the final execution ground, when the Rebels announced the Frostholm Queen's crimes and spoke those words aloud. On that very day, Seawatch Cliff of the Frostholm city-state suffered an unprecedented, terrifying collapse. The entire cliff, along with a quarter of the city, fell into the Boundless Sea. Everyone who heard the words 'Abyssal Trench Project' without exception turned into Restless Souls in the Deep Sea.

"Back then, the Rebels had actually prepared a whole series of follow-up propaganda around the Abyssal Trench Project. They planned to make it widely known, without exposing its forbidden parts, to completely erase the Frostholm Queen's influence in the Northern Seas and to stress the righteousness of the rebellion. But after the great collapse of the cliff, all those plans were scrapped at once. As I just said, they were sure that even the name 'Abyssal Trench Project' had already been corrupted by the curse. So they destroyed every piece of material related to it, including the name itself.

“That’s why I am especially curious… through what channel did you learn the name ‘Abyssal Trench Project’?”

Tyrian finally stopped dodging and met Duncan’s eyes. Ever since he had heard that half-century-old project’s name from Duncan’s mouth, the turmoil in his heart had not settled. For a moment, he even truly began to suspect that there really had been some “collusion” between the Frostholm Queen and the Vanished.

“I told you, I have ‘watched’ some things from the cracks in history,” Duncan said openly, and asked again: “So what exactly was the Abyssal Trench Project? Why was this project so secret and forbidden that even you… still sound a little afraid when you mention it?”

Tyrian’s face grew solemn. After a long silence, he finally spoke in a low, slow voice: “Simply put, it was an exploration project. But unlike those explorers who chart new routes on the edge of civilization, the Abyssal Trench Project explored the Deep Sea.”

“Exploring the Deep Sea?” Duncan frowned. “You mean the Spirit Realm, the Abyssal Deep, and Subspace? If it was only research in those fields, that hardly deserves the word ‘forbidden’, does it? It is dangerous, yes, but research like that has always been legal in every city-state. The Truth Academy even has a dedicated research group…”

“I’m not talking about the Deep Sea as a concept in occult studies,” Tyrian said, gently shaking his head. “I mean the Deep Sea in the true, natural sense. The Deep Sea that lies right in front of all of us, that everyone pretends not to see, does not touch, and does not dare to touch.”

As Tyrian spoke, he suddenly asked: “Father, have you ever wondered about this: beneath our city-states, beneath these sea islands that now carry all of civilization… what does it look like?”

Duncan did not speak.

But under his calm surface, a wave had already risen in his heart.

He really had never thought about that question. Or rather… he had not even realized it was a question that needed asking.

In this world, people were used to using names like “Spirit Realm”, “Abyssal Deep seas”, and “Subspace” to talk about the “depth” of the world. That model of the world’s structure did explain how things worked to some extent. But in truth, it was only an interpretation built on the concepts of occult studies. Strictly speaking, it only described the world’s “dimensional” structure, not the physical structure of the Mortal Realm.

What Tyrian was talking about now clearly was not that conceptual, occult studies-based model of dimensions. He meant the water itself, physically, from the sea surface downward.

In the classic “Mortal Realm–Spirit Realm–Abyssal Deep–Subspace” model, the Deep Sea that Tyrian spoke of lay on the very first layer: the Mortal Realm. Yet this Deep Sea, which belonged only to that first layer, seemed to be a complete blank in human understanding.

Duncan had never considered this question because he carried a set of “common sense” in his mind. He took it for granted that beneath the city-states there must be raised geological structures in the sea, like undersea mountains or uplifted volcanic craters. Deeper down, there would of course be a seabed. But when he carefully recalled everything he had learned since coming to this world, he realized… humans had never done any real research into the underwater world beyond two hundred meters in depth.

“Clearly, you never thought about it either,” Tyrian’s voice suddenly came, cutting off Duncan’s thoughts. “And before I met the Frostholm Queen, I had never thought about it either. The Boundless Sea covers the whole

world. Our city-states are isolated islands floating on the surface. The protection of the Gods laid a solid foundation for the Mortal Realm, and the light of Vision 001 gives us safe, stable daylight. As for what lies under the surface… why should we care? The Deep Sea zones in the Spirit Realm, the Abyssal Deep, and Subspace already give us enough of a headache."

As Tyrian spoke, he gently shook his head.

"But Her Majesty Ray Nora told me this question was important, as important as the secrets of the Spirit Realm, the Abyssal Deep, and Subspace. Right under our feet, beneath the city-states and the sea surface, in our Mortal Realm itself, there is such a vast unknown area. She was full of the spirit of exploration. She could not accept that such a huge region within her rule remained shrouded in ignorance."

Chapter 251: Abyssal Trench

Listening to Tyrian's story, Duncan fell into brief thought. After half a minute, he looked up, speaking slowly: "So, to satisfy her desire to explore, she launched the 'Abyssal Trench Project'. And the real essence of this project was not exploring Subspace at all, but simply… diving into deep water in the literal sense?"

He paused there, feeling that there was something very strange about all this: "But if that's all, how did this plan end up connected to the Vanished? The Subspace the Vanished went to and the Deep Sea the Frostholm Queen wanted to explore are two completely different things. Those Rebels shouldn't be so confused that they can't tell them apart…"

Tyrian did not answer directly. Instead, he suddenly threw out a question: "Don't you find it strange? If it was only diving into the water to explore the sea conditions under the city-state, how could that be called 'forbidden'? Harbor builders and coastal fishermen often have to dive for their work. In safe waters, it is very common to go down a dozen meters or even several dozen. So why did the Frostholm Queen's 'Abyssal Trench Project' become taboo?"

Duncan's gaze grew more and more serious: "…How deep did you dive?"

"Very, very deep. I don't know what depth the Queen herself reached in the end, because I'm not a scholar. I only took part on the edges as a naval commander, and in the later half of the project I was no longer directly involved. But as far as I know, before the plan started to become… 'not

right’, their manned submersible had already reached at least one thousand meters below the surface, and they kept breaking that record.”

A thousand meters underwater…

Duncan quickly sorted through what he knew in his mind. On Earth, that number, which did not look impressive at first glance, was already the maximum diving depth for many advanced military submarines. Most military submarines could only dive four or five hundred meters. As for those “extreme Deep Dive records” of several thousand or even nearly ten thousand meters, they were almost all done by specially built Deep Dive craft for short periods. The demands on the equipment were extreme, and those dives were usually unmanned.

But the Frostholm Queen’s manned submersible back then had already reached the threshold of “one thousand meters”. With this world’s industrial level half a century ago, even with some help from supernatural powers, that was already a staggering number.

And behind that staggering number… there was clearly something even more shocking.

Tyrian had just mentioned that in its later stage the project had started to become “not right”. Duncan did not overlook that phrase.

He looked at Tyrian, his gaze darkening: “I want to know the details of the entire exploration project. Tell me everything you were involved in.”

Maybe because he had already answered many questions, and had adapted to this way of talking, Tyrian did not hesitate for long this time. He sank into his memories and spoke slowly:

“…Aside from Frostholm’s Abyssal Trench Project, the recorded normal diving depth for humans, or the ‘safe water depth’, is one hundred and fifty

meters, and even that is limited to nearshore waters. Our plan also started at that depth, and everything went smoothly up to three hundred meters.

“It was already very, very dark there. sunlight from the surface could not pass through such a heavy layer of water. The powerful lamps on the submersible could only light up a small area. To see the ‘shape’ of the island under the city-state, and to avoid as much as possible some dangerous ‘creatures’ in the open sea, such as Deep Sea Spawn, we had the submersible dive along the coastline and keep close to the island’s nearshore zone. I still remember how the explorer described the scene after coming back up…

“He said the underside of the island looked like an ugly, rough pillar, covered in thick layers of calcareous deposits. Some strange creatures lived in the pits and hollows of that crust. Aside from the ‘pillar’, there was nothing else around, only darkness.”

“A pillar under the island?” Duncan could not help interrupting Tyrian. “Not a gradually widening supporting structure, but a single pillar?”

“Yes. At least, that is how it is under Frostholm,” Tyrian nodded. “Is there a problem with that?”

Duncan shook his head: “…No. Go on.”

Tyrian gathered his thoughts and continued his earlier memories: “That scene was at about three hundred meters, which was also the first submersible’s limit. After we realized that depth was far from enough to explore the Deep Sea, the Queen ordered the scholars to build a second submersible. That submersible was very successful. It dove straight down to eight hundred meters. And through half a meter of high-strength glass, the explorer saw… still the pillar, a straight pillar.

“Of course, compared with the radius of the city-state itself, that ‘pillar’, already at least eight hundred meters long, was still very short in proportion. Rather than a support column, it was more like a neat, disc-shaped base holding up an island.

“After that, we built a third submersible. Because of technical limits, its improvements over the second were quite small. It had to dive very carefully to challenge the second submersible’s record. And it was during that slow descent, meter by meter, that we discovered something.

“The ‘pillar’ beneath the city-state was actually only eight hundred and fifty meters ‘long’. Below that, there was nothing.

“The whole structure floated in the sea.”

Tyrian stopped and looked up into Duncan’s eyes: “Now you understand why I said it was more like a disc-shaped base than a pillar, right?”

Duncan frowned tightly. He did not speak. In his mind, he quickly sketched out the whole structure according to Tyrian’s description.

In the Deep Sea era, people “huddled” inside their city-states. These sea islands had first struck Duncan as cramped and narrow, but in fact, as fully functional, self-sustaining places to live, the city-states had to have a certain basic size. There were some small islands, but most of the major cities with real names had a “base radius” of more than ten kilometers, even several tens. As the largest city-state in the Frost Sea in the past, Frostholm would not be any smaller.

To match that huge structure on the sea, its underwater “base” was “only” eight hundred and fifty meters deep. When the explorers first saw the underwater part of the city at three hundred meters, stretching straight down into the Deep Sea, they instinctively imagined it as a pillar reaching straight

to the “seafloor”. But in terms of proportions, that “pillar” was more like a thin disc.

The vast city sat on top of that “disc”.

Just as Tyrian had said: the whole structure floated in the sea.

But once he pictured this model, a huge doubt rose in Duncan’s heart.

Were all city-states like this?

If every city-state was like this, a rootless “floating thing”, how did they stay so stable? If the stability of a city-state itself came from its sheer size, what about the stable relative positions between city-states? How could that be explained?

The Boundless Sea rolled with endless waves, yet these “floating islands” had never shifted their positions. Why?

Duncan voiced his doubts, but Tyrian only shook his head: “We wondered about that too, but in the end we never figured it out. And compared with what happened later… the question of how city-states float on the sea stopped mattering.”

“What happened later?” Duncan could not help asking. “What happened? What did you actually see in the Deep Sea?”

“Later… the third submersible kept pushing the depth limit. We spent nearly two years raising the record from eight hundred and fifty meters to nine hundred and fifty. As you can imagine, during that descent the submersible gradually moved away from the city-state’s ‘base’. Remember what I said at the beginning? To avoid trouble in the open sea, we had the submersible dive in the ‘nearshore safety zone’ close to the coast. During that whole process, it stayed pressed against the city-state and its underwater ‘structure’. But as the dive went on and the explorer got farther from that ‘base’, things started to go wrong.

“Auditory and visual hallucinations. It felt like strange lights appeared in the water. It felt like someone was knocking on the hull outside, even turning the handle of the hatch. The deeper they went, the worse these things became. Even explorers with special training and strong wills began to feel tremendous pressure during every dive. And the protection given by the Holy Oil, holy books, and scripture cloth they carried grew weaker and weaker.

“Of course, up to that point, everything was still within what we expected. Exploring the unknown always comes with trials of will. Scholars who explore the seas of the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep often face similar troubles. So we continued, only strengthening the explorers’ Mental Ward to the strictest standard.

“The problem came when we tried to push from nine hundred and ninety meters to one thousand.

“The third submersible suddenly sent an emergency signal to surface at once. Then it rushed upward like a mad thing, blowing all the ballast water. The explorer inside seemed not to care at all that such a rapid ascent could kill him. When he burst back to the surface, that explorer was already mad. When the hatch opened, he roared and shouted under the sunlight, as if trying desperately to describe something terrifying to us. After a long flood of chaotic, incomprehensible words, he spoke one single clear sentence:

“We all died down there.”

Chapter 252: The Deep Sea’s Silence

The city-state floated rootless on the Boundless Sea. Beneath its “850-meter-thick” foundation stretched dark water that seemed to have no end. The deeper you dove into the Deep Sea, the more you heard strange noises that could not be understood, and saw lights and shadows that made no sense.

The first explorer who went past a depth of one thousand meters rushed madly back to the surface and then went insane. The only sentence he left to the world was:

“We all died down there.”

That was what happened from the start of Frostholm’s Abyssal Trench Project up to the point when things began to turn wrong.

Duncan fell into a brief silence. He suddenly realized that even without going deep into the Spirit Realm or the Abyssal Deep, even just within this world’s Mortal Realm, the dangers and eerie anomalies hidden in the Boundless Sea were not lacking at all. After that short pause, he asked:

“What happened to that explorer later?”

“He died soon after. The rapid ascent and decompression killed him. After shouting and raving for a while, he died of a vascular embolism. At least, that was the cause on the Mortal Realm level.”

“There was only one person in a submersible?” Duncan asked again.

“It could only hold one person. Of course, that made the mental pressure much greater for the explorer, but we had no choice. On one hand, the technology back then was limited. On the other hand, that kind of exploration was not suited for a group. Under the Deep Sea, it is hard to be sure what might replace the companion beside you in the next second, and it is hard to know whether the voice you hear is real. So it was better to dive alone. At least that way, you did not have to suspect that there was someone else in the submersible.”

“The Deep Sea, darkness, loneliness, leaving the civilized world behind and facing bizarre unknown waters directly… any of that could have driven the explorer mad,” Duncan said, slowly shaking his head. “But that is not the important part. What matters is… this still is not enough to explain why the Abyssal Trench Project later became an absolute taboo.”

He turned his gaze on Tyrian’s eyes and went on: “So far, what you have told me is only an expedition that had an accident. Explorations like this happen every year. The Truth Academy even actively funds and encourages scholars and explorers to do such things. That is not a taboo, and it should not be tied to the Vanished at all.”

“…Yes. If the project had stopped at one thousand meters, none of the later things would have happened,” Tyrian said, shaking his head as he sighed over the past. “After the accident with the No. 3 submersible, Her Majesty Ray Nora once ordered the exploration to be stopped for a time. But a few days later, something happened, and things… slowly became strange.”

Duncan frowned: “Something?”

“At the edge of the sealed test waters, the No. 3 submersible shot up to the surface.”

Duncan froze for a second, then reacted: “A second No. 3 submersible?!”

“Yes, a second one,” Tyrian nodded. “It broke the surface right in front of the navy soldiers and started flashing light signals, asking for help to open its hatch. The well-trained soldiers panicked for a moment, but they still quickly followed standard procedure. They dragged the submersible onto the work platform and aimed twenty-seven rifles, two quick-firing guns, and a flamethrower at its hatch. Then a brave priest stepped forward, sprinkled holy water, and opened the lock.”

Tyrian paused for a moment, then slowly said: “The hatch opened, and a human who looked… very much like the explorer walked out.”

Duncan’s face grew dark: “Very much like?”

“The face and outline were similar, but the height and weight were different. He wore a Frostholm navy uniform, but there were many problems in the details of the clothing. More importantly… the person who came out of the submersible walked on land only for a short while before he died. He did not even have time to say a single word. When the soldiers undid ‘his’ clothes, they found that his flesh and the uniform seemed to have grown into one thing, and his body was covered in large and small wounds that no one could understand.

“After that, doctors and scholars from the Church examined the corpse together. The Queen of Frostholm seemed to have personally gone to see the dissection as well. But the results of the examination were never published. Or rather, before they had time to reveal anything, a third ‘No. 3 submersible’ appeared.”

Even Alice, who had been silent at the side and only listening in fascination, could not help speaking now: “There was a third one?!”

Tyrian glanced at Alice without thinking. His expression looked a bit strange. He clearly was not used to someone who looked exactly like the Queen of Frostholm standing here and shouting in surprise. But he quickly

adjusted his expression and nodded lightly: “A third, and not just three. After that, every twenty-four or forty-eight hours, another ‘No. 3 submersible’ would come up from there…”

Alice listened to this bizarre story in shock. She thought for a moment and suddenly blurted out: “So you just had to wait there, and you would get an endless supply of submersibles? By the way, are those things called ‘submersibles’ very expensive? Are they worth more than cultists?”

Just a second earlier, Tyrian had still been sunk in his memories of the past. Now Miss Doll snapped his train of thought in an instant. He stared with his mouth half open, unable to pull his mood back: “We… never thought about that at the time…”

“Do not mind her. Her way of thinking is different from others’,” Duncan said to Tyrian with a serious look after glancing at Alice. “Go on. What happened after that?”

Tyrian finally came back to himself. After sorting his thoughts, he continued: “When the third submersible came up, it also flashed light signals asking for the hatch to be opened. This time the soldiers had some experience. They dragged the submersible into an even more heavily protected area, and the priest set up a large number of extraordinary wards in advance before opening the hatch. And this time… what came out was a swollen, twisted humanoid monster that no longer looked like an explorer at all.

“That monster also could not survive more than three minutes in the air.

“The fourth submersible had a mass of constantly writhing flesh climb out of it. This time, there was not even a trace of a human outline left.

“When the hatch of the fifth submersible opened, nothing came out. The soldiers on the scene went up to check and saw only a suspicious puddle of

dark red sludge in the cockpit. That sludge carried a faint sign of life.

“The sixth submersible held only a small amount of black, fibrous, dried material. It looked like an unfinished nervous structure, or a dried specimen of blood vessels…”

As Tyrian went on, Duncan’s expression grew more and more serious. Even Alice at his side seemed to sense the change in mood and sat up straight.

In that ever more heavy and solemn air, Tyrian slowly said:

“The seventh submersible, which is also the last one I know of, was empty inside.”

“Empty?” Duncan lifted his eyebrow slightly, then shook his head. “That is even more unsettling.”

“Yes. Empty. So it was even more unsettling. The whole matter had completely entered a runaway state. We had to find a way to end it,” Tyrian said in a deep voice. “But thankfully, the No. 4 submersible was finally finished. It was originally designed as the follow-up model to the No. 3. After the ‘one thousand meters’ incident, the project was paused, and its construction stopped as well. But as more and more ‘No. 3 submersibles’ floated to the surface, the queen ordered the No. 4 submersible to be assembled as fast as possible and decided to use it to find out what had really happened in the water one thousand meters below.”

Tyrian paused, as if his memories had a few gaps. He gathered his words before slowly going on: “I cannot remember all the details of the No. 4 submersible. It was finished in a rush, and the Frostholm navy only handled part of it. I only know it was larger than No. 3. It could hold three people and had a sample bay. The scholars had planned to use it to collect samples from the Deep Sea, if there were samples to collect.

“The day after the seventh ‘No. 3 submersible’ appeared, the No. 4 submersible built by Frostholm was put into the sea. Inside it sat a scholar, an officer, and a powerful priest. At that point, we could no longer worry about the dangers of ‘multi-person exploration’. Preventing an eighth ‘No. 3 submersible’ from appearing was the first priority.

“The No. 4 submersible dove all the way down and soon reached the depth of one thousand meters. The priest inside used spiritual power to stay in touch with the surface. Maybe because the new submersible had better performance, they went down very smoothly and confirmed the sight of the city-state’s ‘foundation’ that the earlier explorer had reported. But soon, the link began to cut in and out. After they reached a depth of one thousand meters, the small cathedral on the sea platform almost could not hear a thing from the Deep Sea.

“But fifteen minutes after the link was broken, the priest on duty in that small cathedral suddenly heard a sound from the Deep Sea again. First they heard a scream. It was the priest in the submersible. In a terrified voice, he screamed to warn the others. He said: ‘Don’t look! Don’t think!’ Right after that came the officer’s voice, a roar. And then, a deafening blast.”

Tyrian raised his head and turned his gaze to Duncan.

“The No. 4 submersible detonated its explosives,” the Pirate Lord said slowly. “They had packed the sample bay full of high-energy charges to deal with ‘the final dangerous situation’.

“Then everything ended. The No. 4 submersible never came back up, and no more ‘No. 3 submersibles’ ever appeared before anyone.”

Chapter 253: Frostholm’s Great Uprising

Tyrian’s story finally reached a pause, but to Duncan, this bizarre tale ended far too abruptly.

“Everything ended? It really just ended like that?” He could not help looking across the mirror at the Pirate Lord, his tone full of doubt. “One submersible, with a bay full of explosives, diving down to one thousand meters, solved a ‘runaway’ extraordinary phenomenon that was still getting worse? Let us not even talk about how much power those explosives could unleash at that depth. Just from the view of the supernatural field… could an explosion like that really destroy a supernatural studies phenomenon?”

“We could only think so,” Tyrian said. He was clearly not surprised by Father’s question. “In truth, no one knew what really happened in the water one thousand meters below. No one knew what the No. 4 submersible saw there. Our only link with the deep was the fragment of perception the priest shared with us through psychic echo… a scream, a roar, and a blast. Those tiny shards were nowhere near enough to piece together the truth.

“But in fact, after the No. 4 submersible exploded, there really were no more ‘No. 3 submersible’ replicants rising from the Deep Sea. So we could only assume… the matter was resolved.”

“The matter was resolved…” Duncan frowned and shook his head. “Fine. Let us assume it was resolved. Then the Abyssal Trench Project…”

“The Abyssal Trench Project did not end. That is exactly what was most wrong about it,” Tyrian said bluntly. “After something like that happened, after we paid such a heavy price and finally dealt with the strange crisis around the No. 3 submersible, we should have reviewed the Abyssal Trench Project and stopped that dangerous scheme. But Her Majesty Ray Nora pushed back against all opposition. Not only did she announce that the project would restart and the No. 5 submersible would be built, she even raised the priority of the Abyssal Trench Project to the very highest level, and she spent an unusual amount of manpower and resources on it.”

Duncan’s gaze suddenly grew deep. He faintly sensed that the real “runaway” part of this matter might have begun here. The queen’s “crime” and that rebellion in Frostholm half a century ago all came from this point.

He turned his gaze on Tyrian’s eyes: “From the sound of it, you did not support your queen at the time.”

“I argued with her. We fought bitterly over it. That is why I say that after the depth of ‘one thousand meters’, I was no longer directly involved in the Abyssal Trench Project,” Tyrian said slowly, his voice low. “After that, I felt the whole thing was sliding toward danger.

“But thinking back, I should have done everything in my power to stop the Queen of Frostholm, not avoid her. I trusted her too much and did not realize that she could make mistakes as well.”

“You believe the Queen of Frostholm really did make a mistake?”

“The Abyssal Trench Project brought a chain of crises to Frostholm and gave her enemies an opening. That ever more extreme exploration finally even cost Her Majesty Ray Nora her life. At least from that point of view, it was a mistake.”

“…After Ray Nora insisted on pushing ahead with the Abyssal Trench Project, what else happened?”

“After that, I did not take part in the project directly, so I do not know much. But from what I heard now and then, the plan did not go smoothly, and… the strange and horrible events kept getting more frequent and more serious,” Tyrian said calmly. “The No. 5 submersible was completed. It used the most advanced engineering techniques and the toughest materials of the time, but every dive it made was accompanied by all kinds of accidents. It was as if something in the dark was blocking humans from going any deeper into the sea…

“People working on the project started going mad. Some were injured for no reason. Some vanished and then wandered back into the city in a daze. The explorers who dove in the submersible became suspicious and violent. They were no longer the careful, respectable scholars and soldiers they had been, but more and more like grim, eerie fanatics. It was even said that the No. 5 submersible itself began to change during those dives. It showed changes no one could understand, and its inner workings became more and more like some kind of… living thing.

“The strangest part of all was that even with all these changes, even as the whole project grew more and more terrifying, the Abyssal Trench Project still went forward without the slightest hesitation. No one involved in the project, no one who lived with madness and accidents every day, and not even the people who were already frequently injured and traumatized, backed out. No one questioned or resisted the orders from above. It felt as though…”

Tyrian stalled. He seemed unable to find the right words to describe the atmosphere back then.

Seeing this, Duncan spoke softly: “As though the Deep Sea was calling them.”

“Yes. As though the Deep Sea was calling them,” Tyrian said, startled. He nodded at once, then gave Duncan a strange look. “That is a very… accurate description.”

“Do not think too much about it. Go on.”

Tyrian looked away and gathered his thoughts again: “That was how it was. The whole project seemed to be called and pushed by some power. It even felt as if the ‘project’ itself had grown some kind of will and was stubbornly marching toward the Deep Sea, while the people working on it had all become cells in that huge will.

“And in that kind of atmosphere, the No. 5 submersible unknowingly passed the depth of one thousand meters. I do not know how deep it finally went. All I heard was… it was an astonishing number, very, very astonishing. From the view of engineering, from the view of materials, from the level of technology at the time… it was a number that should have been impossible.

“The Deep Sea embraced the Abyssal Trench Project. The Deep Sea accepted the No. 5 submersible. That ever stranger machine and its ever stranger crew moved easily through the dark Deep Sea at several thousand meters as if they had gone home. But in the waters around the Abyssal Trench Project… strange incidents grew more and more common.

“Merchant ships began to see ‘reflections’ of themselves near the surface, ships that looked exactly the same as their own. Thick fog began to fall again and again over the eastern part of Frostholm. In the fog drifted shadows that looked sometimes like ships and sometimes like giant beasts. The city-state also began to see… ‘strangers’. A great, great many strangers. They gathered near facilities tied to the Abyssal Trench Project and all

claimed to be part of the project. The number of these strangers was even larger than the actual number of people working on the project.

“In such a situation, rumors… in truth, they could no longer be called rumors. Sayings began to spread everywhere. At first people only said the Queen of Frostholm was doing some suspicious research. Soon, people said she was studying Subspace. After that, they said the Queen of Frostholm was colluding with Subspace, and that she had already reached an agreement with the great leader in Subspace, Captain Duncan…”

Tyrian let out a slow breath and spread his hands. “And after that, you know what happened. The Frostholm Great Uprising that shocked the whole North.”

The little storeroom piled high with “antiques” fell silent for a time. No one knew how long had passed before Duncan’s voice slowly came from the mirror: “It is understandable that people linked this to Subspace. But dragging the Vanished into it… that really took too much imagination.”

“In fact, it was a very normal chain of thought. That line of thinking was even related to me,” Tyrian said with a bitter smile and a shake of his head. “After all, I am your son, and I just happened to serve the Queen of Frostholm, and I had been part of this terrible project in its early stages. You should know, people who love conspiracies always have the strongest imagination.”

Duncan did not comment. After a brief silence, he said again: “Looked at this way, that Great Uprising really was not without cause. The Abyssal Trench Project that Ray Nora insisted on pushing was too dangerous, and from what you describe… her mental state at the time was not quite right either.”

“That is exactly what I wanted to add a few words about,” Tyrian said suddenly. “I know that all signs suggest the Queen of Frostholm had already

lost her reason. She looked like a madman led on by something, stubbornly walking one single path. But I know that she… was always clear-headed. Very clear-headed, very rational, and fully aware of what she was doing."

"Oh?"

"I argued with her, but I was still the general she trusted. I could meet her up close. In fact, the other city-state officials could too. They all knew that the queen had never gone mad and that she had no plan to destroy the city-state or threaten the world. Yes, they knew… but they became afraid, and they hesitated. Some of them were bought off, some were lured away. They were not as firm as I was.

"But I know that maybe the other people in the Abyssal Trench Project were indeed being slowly affected by something. She, however… she clearly resisted that influence and was using it in reverse."

"You mean the Queen of Frostholm actually had a clear and 'safe' plan, and she was confident she could finish it, but she did not tell anyone. She did not even explain it to you," Duncan said, looking at Tyrian with a thoughtful gaze. "And you still trusted her without question? Because you believed that even if something under the Deep Sea threatened the city-state, everything was still under Ray Nora's control?"

"In your eyes, that kind of trust must seem too blind."

"Whether it is blind or not is your business," Duncan said, shaking his head. "I only mean that the Queen of Frostholm clearly did not manage to keep 'everything under control'. She died in the hands of the rebels in the end, and the Abyssal Trench Project was buried completely. Things did not unfold the way she planned."

"…I really could not argue with that."

Tyrian let out a helpless sigh.

Chapter 254: Perhaps It Was Not Over Yet

By this point, Duncan finally understood the whole story of the Abyssal Trench Project, which had been sealed away for half a century. He now knew why it was seen as a taboo, and why even the Rebels who had started the Frostholm uprising were deeply afraid of it—they truly had every reason to be afraid.

Even though the whole thing had taken place from beginning to end within the Mortal Realm, once the situation entered a runaway state, it clearly went beyond the order of the Mortal Realm. Beneath the Deep Sea lay a completely unknown terror. Even in the end, no one ever figured out what it really was. People only kept falling into madness, and the entire project only sped up, as if it was sliding toward an abyss.

There was the endless Deep Dive, the strange mood that slowly spread, and the Queen of Frostholm's later behavior, which was almost like shutting herself away from the world… To be fair, even Duncan himself, looking at this chain of facts, would instinctively think that Ray Nora had truly been tempted and controlled by something. He would even suspect that the Queen of Frostholm had joined hands with Subspace.

In such a situation, it was not just that Frostholm already had hidden opponents of the Queen inside its walls. It was not just that many city-states in the Frost Sea already held ill intentions toward Frostholm and the

Queen’s rule. Even if the northern situation had once been steady, under such pressure, undercurrents would still have risen with time.

But Tyrian kept stressing that Ray Nora had never been influenced by anything. He firmly believed that the Queen of Frostholm had stayed clear-minded until the end, and had protected the city-state until the end.

Duncan could not say for sure whether Tyrian’s judgment was right, but he tended to believe it, because… he had also seen that Queen of Frostholm in the fragments of history.

She had even calmly and rationally asked him: “Please don’t corrupt history.”

At least from that one meeting, the Queen of Frostholm in those days had not looked like some terrible madman controlled by Subspace.

But it was exactly because of this that Duncan felt even more curious. He could not figure out what kind of motive would make a clear-headed city lord make those withdrawn and extreme decisions. What could drive her to keep pushing the Abyssal Trench Project at all costs, even when she knew there was something wrong with it? And what reason could make her lock all those secrets in her heart and say nothing, not even in front of the navy commander she trusted the most?

After thinking for a long time, Duncan found that all the questions pointed to one thing in the end: what kind of “secret” had the Queen of Frostholm learned in the Deep Sea?

“…After the Frostholm Great Uprising, you never returned to that city-state?” Duncan raised his head and looked at Tyrian as he asked.

“No. Her Majesty Ray Nora once ordered me to lead my direct troops out of Frostholm. At that time, the Rebels had already joined forces with other northern city-states, and they had gathered an entire fleet on the outer sea,”

Tyrian said. His voice grew especially low; it was clearly a past he did not want to bring up. “…But if I had disobeyed the order and stayed, Frostholm would have had one more unit still loyal to the Queen. Those Rebels would never have broken through the defenses of the Harbor so easily…”

“So in later years there were rumors that you actually took part in the uprising, and that you were even the one who let the Rebels into Frostholm,” Duncan said as he shook his head. “Have you ever thought about why the Queen of Frostholm gave that order back then? Did she leave you no other instructions?”

“…I was confused by it for many years,” Tyrian said honestly. “The Queen gave no further orders. She only told me to leave with my troops. I once thought that maybe she wanted to leave a force behind to avenge her in the future, but… that made no sense. She forbade us from ever returning to the city, and the Rebels took the city. If we could not go back, how could we avenge her?”

“You could raid the Rebels’ fleets on the outer sea and intercept every merchant going in and out of Frostholm. You did that for many years.”

“Yes. That was the only thing I could think to do, and it was also the only way to keep the Sea Mist Fleet alive… At that time we did not even have a home port,” Tyrian said, shaking his head. “But now we have slowly stopped those raids.”

“Why?”

“…Because the last Rebel leader is dead now. He died of old age,” Tyrian said with a bitter smile as he spread his hands. “We did everything we could to hunt down those Rebel leaders. When we caught one, we hanged him from the mast, then threw the body onto merchant ships bound for Frostholm. So they got smart. They all hid inside the city and did not step beyond its walls for decades. I could only watch as they lived out their lives

in peace, until everyone who had taken part in the uprising had left this world."

Duncan did not speak for a while. He stayed silent in thought for a long time before he suddenly said: "All of your soldiers are 'Living dead', right?"

Tyrian answered without thinking: "Yes. Everyone knows that."

"They also all took part in the Abyssal Trench Project, directly or indirectly?"

"I took part in that project. They were my direct troops, so of course they took part too," Tyrian said offhand. Then he frowned slightly. "Have you thought of something?"

"You all took part in the Abyssal Trench Project, but unlike the others involved, you did not become insane and twisted in the later stages. After 'one thousand meters', the Queen of Frostholm quarreled with you and pushed you out of the project. Then, on the eve of the Rebel assault, your Queen ordered you to lead your direct troops away from Frostholm…"

Duncan spoke slowly as he thought. In the end, his gaze fell on Tyrian, and his voice grew low: "You are right. That Queen of Frostholm may really have wanted to leave a force behind. But she did not seem to leave this force to avenge herself…"

Tyrian slowly showed a stunned look. Just as he was about to ask something more, the figure in the mirror shook his head lightly and said: "Don't ask me. If you can't figure it out yourself, I can't either. I only said what I thought, from the view of an onlooker."

After that, the room fell into a brief silence. After who knew how long, Duncan's voice sounded again: "Tyrian, we have talked long enough this time."

The Pirate Lord, who was still lost in thought, looked up at these words. He stared at the Father in the mirror in some surprise, as if he only then realized something. A complicated, shocked look appeared in his eyes.

He seemed to have just realized how much he had told the other side, and realized that, without noticing it, he had fully grown used to the mood of this conversation. Even a century ago, he had rarely had such a long talk with the Father. As for the bit of wariness he had felt when he first woke up here… it had already vanished at some point.

“I…” He tried to speak without thinking, but a sudden sting came from his forehead. He could not help touching his brow. “Ah… that hurts…”

“…The child didn’t know her own strength. I hope you won’t hold it against her,” Duncan’s voice came from the mirror. “Do you need some salve?”

“No… no need,” Tyrian said. His expression was a bit strange as he waved his hand. He could not help thinking of the last scene he remembered before coming here: that strange little young lady, and that thing that had flown at him through the air… something like a dog. Then he suddenly reacted: “Wait, I remember now. That wasn’t a dog. That was a Abyssal Hound!”

He looked toward the mirror, disbelief in his eyes: “Is that also one of your subordinates now? An… Annihilator?”

When he said the words “Annihilator”, he sounded a little unsure. He clearly did not dare to claim Shirley’s true nature. He had seen Annihilators before, but this was the first time he had seen one rush in swinging a contracted demon like a club…

“She is doing some work for me,” Duncan said with a faint, unreadable smile. “But if you ever get the chance to meet her again, I suggest you don’t use the word ‘Annihilator’ in front of her. She dislikes it very much.”

Tyrian made a muddled sound of agreement, then looked around the room without thinking. His eyes finally fell on Alice, who already seemed to be spacing out beside him.

Alice quickly snapped back to herself and looked at Tyrian in curiosity: “Why are you looking at me?”

“Nothing,” Tyrian said as he pulled back his gaze. Something complicated, some feeling, hid in his eyes. In the end he looked at the mirror that was still burning with flames and asked, not very sure: “Then I… can leave now?”

“Do you want to stay for dinner?”

Tyrian quickly waved his hands: “Ah… no, that won’t be necessary…”

“Very well. Then I’ll have my messenger send you…” Duncan in the mirror nodded. But then he suddenly frowned, as if something had come to him. “Wait. I just thought of something.”

Tyrian tensed up a little without meaning to: “Something?”

“Strictly speaking, it’s two doubts about the same thing,” Duncan said. His face grew serious again as he stared at Tyrian. “Do you remember what you just mentioned, about several ‘replicas’ of Submersible No. 3 surfacing one after another?”

“Of course,” Tyrian said with a nod. “Counting the first original and the six later replicants, seven ‘Submersible No. 3s’ surfaced in total.”

“I have two questions,” Duncan said slowly after putting his thoughts in order. “First, was that first submersible that surfaced back then… really the original?

“Second, was the seventh submersible that surfaced really empty inside?”

Chapter 255: A Brief Farewell

Half a century after the Abyssal Trench Project had ended, Tyrian finally once again felt a chill that had flowed on from that project all the way to this very day.

Those Submersible No. 3s that had surfaced one after another seemed to appear before his eyes again. Along with them, his mind brought up the careful soldiers, the stern priests, and the Queen of Frostholm standing there with a cold, silent face. He seemed to see again the hatches of those submersibles opening. Out of them came mad explorers, came humans that looked right but were not, came swollen, twisted monsters, squirming, shifting chunks of flesh, dead and eerie sludge, dried and suspicious black fibers, and… the empty cabin of the seventh Submersible No. 3.

“At that time, the platform had extremely strict protections. There were many priests and Guardian Wardens on site,” Tyrian said, frowning as he recalled. “But… I have to admit, your question is a bit frightening.”

Duncan did not say anything. After a few seconds he suddenly asked: “How did you deal with those ‘Submersible No. 3s’ in the end?”

“Except for the first one that surfaced, the ‘genuine one’, the other six replicants were all thrown into the Crucible. They were melted down into ingots in the holy fire, then poured into the sea. Even though they were a huge pile of metal, no one dared to keep them,” Tyrian said, his tone a little hesitant. “But if it’s as you say, and even the first one wasn’t the ‘genuine one’, then things would be…”

“Where was the first one kept?”

“If you’re asking where it is now, I don’t know,” Tyrian said, shaking his head. “The Rebels should have destroyed everything related to the Abyssal Trench Project. But no one knows how they destroyed those materials. Maybe they just took them apart and reused them?

“But if you mean in the time before the uprising… after it was retired, Submersible No. 3 was kept in a warehouse in the Harbor district.”

Duncan stayed silent for a few seconds, then let out a light breath: “I understand… Tyrian, thank you for being willing to tell me so much. No matter what, this information has greatly satisfied my curiosity.”

Tyrian, however, looked heavy-hearted. Looking back after so many years to analyze that Abyssal Trench Project again, he had sensed far too many chilling details in it. The project itself had always been full of strange things, but this backward glance into the secret brought a kind of unease that seemed to seep into his bones even more than actually living through it had. The doubt Father had raised about the Queen of Frostholm’s last order made him faintly feel that this old case, which should have ended fifty years ago, had in fact never really ended.

But no matter what, today’s talk was over.

Father had no intention of keeping him here.

Suddenly, the sound of flapping wings came from the side. Tyrian looked toward the sound and saw only the shadow of a bird, wrapped in ghostly green fire, flash through the air. In the place where that shadow passed, bright green flames roared up. The fire rose and twisted, and in the blink of an eye it formed a swirling doorway.

Father’s voice came from the mirror beside him: “Walk through it. You’ll be sent to somewhere near the Grand Cathedral—I think you won’t tell anyone

what has happened here."

"Of course. I've never been an informer."

Tyrian answered, then looked at the flaming doorway. He seemed a bit hesitant, but in the end he made up his mind and stepped forward. Yet just before he crossed the door, he stopped again. He couldn't help turning back to look at the doll in a Brother's robe, standing quietly beside the mirror.

"Anomaly 099…" he muttered under his breath, almost to himself. "It's really too similar…"

"They say Anomaly 099 first appeared on the Frost Sea, near the waters where the Queen of Frostholm was executed and fell into the sea," Duncan's voice sounded from the mirror. "I have the same suspicion as you. But even Alice herself can't explain her origin. Just as you said… there are far too many things in the Deep Sea that we can't understand."

Tyrian looked thoughtful. After a moment of silence he suddenly spoke: "It looks like this doll enjoys staying by your side."

Duncan answered lightly: "At first she clung on and refused to leave, but later I found she could be useful."

Alice's answer was far simpler. She laughed happily and nodded as she said: "I like being by the captain's side. He's amazing!"

Tyrian looked in some surprise at the expressionless Father in the mirror, then at Alice, whose face was exactly the same as the Queen of Frostholm's, though in every way but her looks she was nothing like the Queen. After a moment, he suddenly laughed.

It was a kind of lightness and joy that came straight from his heart.

Then he turned around and stepped into the flaming doorway without any hesitation.

The warehouse grew quiet again.

Alice looked toward the direction where the fire had faded, then turned to look at the mirror beside her. After thinking for quite a while, she suddenly blurted out: “Captain, why was he smiling at us just now?”

Duncan replied casually: “How would I know?”

Alice made a confused little sound, thought again, then blurted out another line: “You were talking about Frostholm and that trench thing just now… does it have anything to do with me?”

This time, Duncan did not casually make something up to fool the doll. He thought about it very seriously, then said in a deep voice: “It might.”

“Then can I understand it?”

“It’ll probably be hard.”

“Oh, then I won’t think about it for now,” Alice said, scratching her head. She then smiled and looked at Duncan in the mirror: “Anyway, if there’s anything I need to do or help with, just tell me what to do.”

“I will.”

“Mm!”

…

A flash of fire passed through a dark alley. A moment later, a drowsy Tyrian walked out of the alley and saw the tall doors of Pland’s Grand Cathedral not far away.

“It really did send me nearby…”

The Pirate Lord muttered a line, then lifted his hand to tap his head, which still felt dull from the blow that had left him dazed. But he accidentally touched the swollen spot and sucked in a sharp breath of pain at once.

That little girl's strength was a bit too scary… That was a Abyssal demon heavier than two or three grown men put together!

Thinking of how he had gotten the wound on his head, Tyrian couldn't help grumbling to himself. At the same time, he couldn't help feeling curious.

His own Father was indeed gathering a new crew. At least from what he had seen so far, Father had already taken control of Anomaly 099 and had a strange girl who could summon Abyssal demons and wield great power working for him. But that was clearly not all.

Even if he had learned this only yesterday, it would have been more than enough to make him extremely wary, even to the point of wanting to warn the city-states and the Church. But right now, he had no desire at all to "inform" on Father to the Church.

Now his head was full of thoughts about the Abyssal Trench Project.

Tyrian walked toward the Storm Cathedral. After only a few steps, he saw several figures appear at the cathedral doors and jog toward him.

They were the sailors he had sent back earlier.

Their captain had vanished for a whole day after leaving them only a single line of explanation. That had clearly made his men uneasy.

In a moment, the sailors reached Tyrian. Before even coming to a full stop, one of them began to babble: "You're finally back, sir! The Sun is almost down. Where did you go?"

Another sailor saw at once that something was off about Tyrian and gasped: "Captain, your face is hurt… and how did your head swell up that much?!"

Tyrian had known he couldn't hide how battered he looked. He had hoped his healing ability, which was far beyond that of an ordinary person, might let him recover before he returned to the Grand Cathedral. But it turned out

that, even if that strange girl still had a lot to learn about handling Abyssal demons, wounds made by Abyssal demons were still very troublesome. It had already been half a day, and his head was still swollen.

“…I tripped on the way.”

After holding it in for a long time, Tyrian still could only brush it off with that clumsy excuse.

He really couldn’t bring himself to admit, in front of his own men, that this was the result of “Dad-inflicted damage”—especially when Father hadn’t even done it himself. The one who had hit him was just a little young lady whose head barely reached his chest.

“Tripped?” The sailor who had spoken first looked at his captain in confusion. “Then your fall was a bit… too advanced. It’s like you used your head to beat Pland’s walls and streets to death…”

Tyrian stared at this sailor with a deep look and said, word by word: “I. Tripped. On. The. Way.”

The sailor shivered and came to his senses at once: “Oh, oh, right, yes. You clearly just slipped by accident. I’ll put some medicine on it for you when we get back…”

“Enough. I don’t want to discuss this right now,” Tyrian sighed as he walked toward the cathedral doors. “Let’s go back first. I need a good rest today. Then it’ll be time to set out for the north.”

“Go back north? We’re not staying here a few more days? You were still planning to…”

The words “Abyssal Trench Project” surfaced in Tyrian’s mind again. He waved his hand: “Enough. It’s time to go back. There’s still work to do in the Frost Sea…”

The sailors looked at each other, then in the end nodded and obeyed their captain’s decision.

But Tyrian suddenly stopped walking again.

He hesitated for a moment in front of the main doors of the Storm Cathedral, touching the swollen areas on his face and head.

“Let’s go back through the side door.”

Chapter 256: The Swift Bell Rang

After Tyrian returned to his room, he ordered his men to leave one by one, but his mood did not settle just because the room had fallen quiet.

His long talk with Father still lingered in his mind. Memories of the Abyssal Trench Project wrapped around his thoughts as if they were out of his control. From time to time, fragments from half a century ago flashed before his eyes—the rugged Diving Apparatus, the sea cliffs where cold rain never stopped falling, the silent Guard Corps on the platform, the priests' low benedictions in the rainy nights, the brightly lit yet always eerie coastal laboratory, and the Frostholm Queen's gaze, always fixed on the sea and hiding all secrets.

Tyrian shook his head. For some reason, he suddenly thought again of that Doll who called herself "Alice"—Anomaly 099, who had completely slipped free of her seal and now moved freely in the mortal world.

A "controlled" Anomaly. A Doll who could think and talk like a human, who even had her own joys, anger, sorrow, and happiness…

She was so much like the Frostholm Queen, yet she was definitely not the Queen herself. Even though her existence and the way she appeared in the world easily made people think of some kind of "return" of the Queen, Tyrian could feel that inside that Doll… there was not the slightest trace of Ray Nora's will.

If he had to put it into words, Tyrian felt that Alice was more like a replica whose outer appearance had been restored to perfection, while the inside

was completely twisted.

Just like those “Number Three” Submersibles that had surfaced one after another back then.

Tyrian’s expression changed slightly, and the comparison that rose in his mind brought a thin chill with it.

He sat in the room and poured himself a glass of strong liquor, using the alcohol’s warmth to thaw his cold thoughts and soothe his restless mind. After quite a while, when he felt a little better, he finally looked up at the ornate carrying case by the bed.

After a slight hesitation, he carried the case to the table, opened the lid, and activated the complex array of lenses and the crystal set at their center.

The scrying crystal lit up. Countless flickering points of light appeared within it, along with a buzzing noise that set one’s teeth on edge.

Only after a long time did he finally see Lucretia’s figure faintly appearing among the flashing lights, along with her blurred voice. Another two or three minutes passed before the sound and image barely grew clear, and his younger sister’s voice reached his ears: “Can you hear me?”

“It’s clear now,” Tyrian said with a nod. “Why is the interference on your side worse than before…? What’s around you? sunlight? It looks a bit strange…”

He noticed faint bands of pale golden radiance drifting in the background behind Lucretia. It looked as if brilliant evening clouds were pouring through a window into the room. Yet the quality of that light was far warmer and brighter than sunset glow, and the way it spread and hung in the air felt not quite like sunlight, which made it all the more striking.

Tyrian knew his younger sister often operated along the border, where strange phenomena happened all the time and were often dangerous, though

Lucretia always managed to turn danger into safety. Even so, he still could not help but worry.

“Ah, I picked up something odd on the border, but I’ve already checked it carefully. It’s harmless,” Lucretia answered casually. “The thing probably fell from the sky. It can project a very wide halo of light… I’m using the Radiant Star to drag it back for study.”

Tyrian frowned without thinking. “You’re always picking up strange things on the border. Have you already forgotten how a mass of humanoid smoke dragged you straight into the depths of the Spirit Realm last time?”

“I’ll be careful. I’m always careful—accidents just happen from time to time. That’s exploration; accidents are inevitable.” Lucretia waved her hand, then suddenly seemed to notice something. She stared fixedly at Tyrian’s face. “Brother, what happened to your face and head?”

“…I fell.”

“But it looks more like you repeatedly slammed your head into a city wall,” Lucretia said with a frown. “You can’t fall and turn out like this without a two-hundred-meter running start and one resolute headbutt. You were attacked.”

Tyrian’s expression stiffened for a moment. Then he shook his head helplessly. “Sometimes I really wish you weren’t this smart.”

“Who attacked you?” Lucretia ignored his attempt to change the subject. Her expression grew very serious. “You’re in the city-state of Pland. You have no enemies there, and the city’s authority would never sit by and let a ‘guest’ be assaulted… Ah, and just now you refused to admit you were attacked and said you fell…”

As she spoke, Lucretia suddenly stopped. She seemed to think of something; her expression changed at once, and her eyes began to flicker as

she watched the area around the scrying crystal.

Tyrian knew what that look meant as soon as he saw it. Before she could speak, he shook his head. “Don’t worry. He’s not here.”

“Seriously… he hit you?” Lucretia’s eyes widened in shock. “Wait, wasn’t he supposed to be outside the city-state? And why would he…”

“He’s not here. It was one of his subordinates,” Tyrian said, rubbing his forehead in frustration. “Relax, we didn’t actually fight. These injuries are just a small accident. He wanted to talk to me about something, and I was a bit too wary.”

“Subordinate?!” Lucretia was startled. Her first instinct was to ask how strong that subordinate was and what weapon it took to beat the Iron Vice Admiral into a pig’s head, but then she caught the second half of Tyrian’s sentence. Her gaze changed. “…He sought you out again so soon. What happened?”

“He’s become interested in some old business about Frostholm,” Tyrian said casually. “But you don’t need to worry about that. I’m calling because I want to ask about something else—Anomaly 099. You know of it, don’t you?”

“Of course I do. I also know it was snatched away by the Vanished. That news spread throughout the Explorer Association. Not long after that, the Deep Sea Church issued a notice. Anomaly 099’s name changed from ‘Doll spirit coffin’ to just ‘Doll’… A lot of people had uneasy guesses about what that meant.”

Tyrian lifted his eyelids and looked at Lucretia with a grave expression. “Then do you know why its name changed from ‘Doll spirit coffin’ to just ‘Doll’?”

Lucretia’s fine brows furrowed. She seemed to faintly realize something.

“I’ve seen her,” Tyrian said at last, letting out a breath and dropping the pretense. “That ‘Doll’. She calls herself Alice, and she has already awakened from the spirit coffin. She is now serving at Father’s side. Just like the rumors say, that Doll looks exactly like the Frostholm Queen, but her personality… is completely unexpected.”

“That information is completely unexpected as well,” Lucretia said softly. In the strange golden glow, her eyes seemed to faintly shine. “You mean Father ‘released’ Anomaly 099 from the spirit coffin, let that dangerous Anomaly roam freely outside, and she now willingly follows Father? She can even have a conversation with you?”

“It sounds impossible, but it’s the truth,” Tyrian said with a nod. “She can speak and think, and she has emotions like a human. She even… seems to have a good relationship with Father. But I don’t dare assume it’s a kind of ‘friendship’ humans can understand. After all, one of them is a ghost who returned from Subspace, and the other is an Anomaly entity with a number under one hundred.”

Lucretia stayed silent. After a brief pause, she finally raised her head. “So what is it you want to ask?”

“About the circumstances when Anomaly 099 was first discovered. You were on the scene back then.” Tyrian fixed his gaze on his younger sister. “I want the most genuine information from you. You know I and my fleet never go near Frostholm. We missed the original site.”

Lucretia thought for a few seconds. “Back then… I did happen to be in the waters where it happened. But the first ship to haul up Anomaly 099 wasn’t the Radiant Star. It was a coastal fishing vessel called the Charvin. Strictly speaking, by the time I received the Charvin’s distress signal and found that fishing boat drifting in a runaway state, it was already the second scene. So

I can’t be sure what things looked like the moment Anomaly 099 was first brought aboard—I can only tell you what I saw on the Charvin at the time.”

Lucretia paused, recalling the scenes she had witnessed.

“When I found that ship, there were almost no living people left on board. Of the twelve crew members including the captain, eleven had already been decapitated—only one sailor remained, half mad with fear. He babbled to me about the ‘cursed wooden chest’ they had hauled up.

“He said they couldn’t throw the chest overboard, because it was alive and moved all over the ship. They couldn’t destroy it either, because it had enormous strength and was incredibly tough. The sailors with their little self-defense weapons simply couldn’t deal with it…

“You can find most of this part in the public records of the Explorer Association. But there is one detail… that isn’t recorded there, and you might find it interesting.

“Within the first half hour after Anomaly 099 was hauled up, the sailors on the Charvin heard several faint clicking sounds coming from inside the chest. It sounded as if… something inside was taking shape.”

“Faint clicking…” Tyrian murmured, his brow furrowed. He seemed about to ask something more, but just as he opened his mouth, a sudden, rather urgent bell rang outside the window and cut him off.

He looked up in surprise. The bell sounded clear and rapid under the darkening sky. He listened carefully for a moment, then muttered to himself, not entirely sure, “That’s not the dusk Bell… It sounds like the Swift Bell.”

“The Swift Bell…” Lucretia’s voice came from the scrying crystal. “I heard seven short peals. If I remember correctly, that bell means the Nameless King’s Tomb is sending a message?!”

Chapter 257: “Politeness”

The Swift Bell kept ringing urgently: seven short peals in a row, then after a few seconds’ pause, another seven, three rounds in total.

Tyrian listened hard to the sounds outside the window. He heard voices talking in the corridor and hurried footsteps in the yard outside.

The intermediate and higher-ranking priests were answering the bell. They were setting up defenses at all key locations and preparing for Nightwatch, while the highest-ranking people in the great Cathedral should already have gone to some hidden sanctuary, ready to take part in the Saints’ gathering.

Tyrian was not of the Church, but he had lived for half a century and knew these rules well enough. From the bell’s rhythm and repetition, he could pick out the key information—this was the bell that summoned a Listening Rite, a gathering invitation sent directly from the Nameless King’s Tomb, and it sounded quite urgent.

“Is there another Anomaly or Vision acting up? A new discovery? Or a major change in an old one?” Lucretia muttered thoughtfully. “It feels like it hasn’t been that long since the last ‘summons’…”

Tyrian listened to the commotion outside for a while, then pulled his attention back and shook his head. “This is the Deep Sea Church’s own business. We don’t need to get involved.”

“Mm.” Lucretia nodded lightly, then looked at her elder brother. “Do you have anything else you want to ask about Anomaly 099?”

Tyrian thought for a moment, then shook his head. “No, nothing more—and with the Swift Bell ringing at night, the Cathedral will soon enter Nightwatch. We’d better not keep talking about anything related to Anomalies.”

“All right, then I’ll get back to my own work,” Lucretia said at once. The scrying crystal on the table began to flicker, and her figure started to fade. But just before the link broke completely, she seemed to think of something and suddenly spoke again. “Oh, one more thing. It’s about Father.”

Tyrian hesitated a little. “…Go on.”

“When Father met you this time… did he seem in his right mind as well?”

“He was very lucid, his logic clear. He even seemed…” Tyrian hesitated noticeably at this point, but finally said it anyway. “I can’t be sure, but he was almost… kind.”

“Ah. That’s really good.”

…

Vanna rushed into the great cathedral and saw Bishop Valentine already waiting for her before the Goddess’s statue. She hurried a few steps forward. “Why is there another summons so soon…? This has never happened before.”

“No idea. This time the bell was rung directly under the Storm Cathedral’s control. It would never sound without a reason.” Valentine nodded to Vanna, then turned and walked quickly toward the passage leading to the “Flooded Cavern” as he spoke. “It may be the same as last time. There was a direct change in the list of Anomalies and Visions, and the Tomb’s Gravekeeper is sending out a summons.”

Vanna followed the old bishop’s steps. As she passed the Goddess’s statue, she stopped out of habit and seemed to hesitate for a moment, but soon

bowed devoutly as she always did, then turned and continued toward the passage entrance.

It did not take long for them to reach the chamber at the end of the passage —the Flooded Cavern used to build the psychic channel.

The scene in the chamber was as it always was. The stone-block walls were old and perpetually damp. In the center of the room, phantom flames burned in a brazier, and the fine trickle of water and the layered sound of waves filled the air, bringing a strange, quiet atmosphere.

The chamber’s heavy door closed.

Vanna drew a slow breath and stopped before the brazier, lowering her head to fix her gaze on the flames that burned fiercely without any fuel.

She let her thoughts settle little by little, letting her Spiritual Insight slowly synchronize with the Goddess’s guidance. The dancing flames became an anchor that steadied her humanity, filling her field of vision.

This should have been a familiar process, but this time Vanna found it rather difficult.

She tried her best not to picture the flames suddenly turning ghostly green, not to picture a pair of Captain Duncan’s eyes hidden behind them. She turned her head slightly to look at Bishop Valentine beside her and saw that the old man’s gaze was already utterly calm, his breathing even. He had clearly entered the gathering place ahead of her.

Vanna had no choice but to pull her gaze back, take another light breath, and try again to focus her mind, letting her Spiritual Insight align with the Goddess’s guidance.

Fortunately, this time she succeeded.

Illusory seawater surged up and gently wrapped around her. Her senses pulled free from her mortal body and reassembled in another dimension. Vanna felt a brief daze, and then she was already standing in that mysterious, ancient meeting place—the familiar boundless plaza, the broken, age-old pillars standing around it, and the vague human-shaped shadows gathered between those pillars.

One of the shadows quickly drifted toward her. It was Bishop Valentine. “Vanna, trouble getting in? You took quite a long time this time.”

“Couldn’t focus,” Vanna replied casually. Right after that, she noticed a striking figure standing at the edge of the plaza—that figure was solid and clear, completely different from the Saints around her, who were nothing but blurry shadows. It was plainly a beautiful lady in splendid robes.

Of course Vanna recognized that figure.

“The Pope is already here in person?” she asked in some surprise. “Ah, I really… chose the worst time to be late.”

“It’s fine. After you’re late enough times, you get used to it,” Valentine said in an easy tone. “The Pope was already here when I arrived. She might even have been the first one. I imagine she has some special arrangements in mind…”

Vanna listened half-heartedly. For some reason, she kept feeling that solid, elegant figure was glancing in this direction from time to time, and that gaze made her feel rather awkward, even… nervous.

Just then, Pope Helena suddenly turned her head.

She truly looked straight at Vanna for a moment. Then a faint smile seemed to appear on her face, and she gave a small nod.

Vanna froze for a second. She had just started to return the greeting when a deep rumble suddenly cut her off.

She looked toward the sound and saw the flagstone ground at the center of the plaza heave upward. The broken slabs rippled like water, and in moments an ancient, gloomy palace built from pale giant stones rose into the Saints' view.

The Nameless King's Tomb had appeared.

The Saints who had been murmuring to one another fell silent at once. A quiet, solemn mood settled over the plaza. Vanna hurriedly reined in her thoughts, stopped paying attention to the Pope's gaze on her, and fixed her eyes on the palace's pyramid-like main structure, staring at its entrance.

The doors at the entrance opened, and the towering Gravekeeper stepped out.

Wrapped head to toe in the shroud, one side of his body charred and the other side bound in chains, he looked just as he had last time. This terrifying being, a mix of mortal flesh, iron shackles, and the curse of death, walked straight toward the Saints gathered in the plaza.

The choice had already been made.

In the next moment, he strode without hesitation past every other shadow in the plaza and stopped right in front of Vanna.

The Gravekeeper lowered his head, his single eye calmly turning its gaze on the Saint before him:

"You may enter the tomb chamber."

He raised his hand and passed over a quill and a sheet of parchment, waiting for Vanna's response.

Vanna, however, froze for a moment—and almost all the Saints did the same.

The Gravekeeper had chosen the same Saint to enter the tomb twice in a row.

This had never happened in the past countless years.

Of course, there was no explicit “rule” that the Gravekeeper could not choose the same Saint twice in a row. But over all these years, he had always picked different Saints in two neighboring summons. It had almost become an unwritten rule. Even if a Saint who had entered the tomb last time came again to the gathering, it was only to obey orders and make sure the Listening rite ritual was complete.

No one had expected Vanna to be chosen again.

Vanna stood there stunned for several seconds while the Gravekeeper patiently held out his hand and waited. At that moment, the feeling of being watched came over her again. She instinctively followed it and looked up—right into Pope Helena’s deep gaze.

Vanna’s heart tightened, and she guiltily shifted her eyes away. Only then did she notice that the Gravekeeper was still waiting. The ancient caretaker, terrifying as he looked, lowered his head without joy or sorrow and held the parchment and quill out a little farther.

“Me again?”

Vanna asked without thinking, and regretted it as soon as the words left her mouth—how could the Gravekeeper bother answering such pointless questions?

But right after that, she heard a hoarse, low voice speak from in front of her. “Yes. You again.”

Vanna could not help being a little shocked. She looked up at the Gravekeeper’s somewhat savage face and finally reached out to take the parchment and quill.

The Gravekeeper seemed to give a tiny nod as he straightened up and said:

“Please write down what you hear on it.”

Vanna nodded without thinking, but suddenly felt that something was off.

She couldn’t shake the feeling… that this Gravekeeper had grown a lot more polite?

Chapter 258: No Number

Not only Vanna faintly felt that something was wrong. The nearby Saints also sensed that something was off. These hazy spirit projections looked almost instinctively at the ancient being wrapped in the shroud, its face twisted and terrifying.

In their memories, and in the Church's records, every description of this "Gravekeeper" used words like "cold," "dutiful," and "indifferent." There was never a single line saying that he would ever say "please" to a chosen Listener.

However, Vanna did not have time to think about it. She noticed that the Gravekeeper was still patiently waiting for her, so she quickly gathered her thoughts and nodded: "All right."

The Gravekeeper turned and led Vanna toward the grand, ancient mausoleum palace, leaving the Saints on the plaza watching the two figures grow distant.

The heavy gate of the mausoleum closed behind them, as if it cut off all the sounds of the world. Standing in the cold and silent corridor, Vanna's heart slowly calmed down as well.

This was already her second time entering this mausoleum. Compared with the slightly nervous and uneasy mood of her first visit, she had now gotten at least a little used to it.

She knew what she had to do next. She had to walk straight ahead, pass through the passage lined with messages left by the seniors, enter the

deepest burial chamber, and see the body of the Nameless King. After that, she would forget everything she had seen and heard and be sent back out of the mausoleum—while the parchment sheet in her hand would keep the notes she had written herself.

The secrets that could not be taken out of the mausoleum would be torn away. The things that could be revealed to the world would remain. The corruption she suffered during the process of the Listening rite would be safely left behind in the burial chamber together with her “forgetting.”

Vanna steadied herself and stepped forward.

A slightly heavy footstep followed behind her.

The young Inquisitor stopped in surprise and looked back at the Gravekeeper walking after her.

Under normal circumstances, did the Gravekeeper not always leave on his own once the Listener entered the mausoleum?

“Is there… something else?” Vanna could not help speaking. She chose her words carefully and stayed fully on guard.

The Gravekeeper lowered his gaze. The single eye outside the shroud was cloudy. A hoarse voice sounded from his chest: “No. I am only escorting you—do you need an escort?”

That strong sense of wrongness rose again.

Vanna had only entered the mausoleum once before and was not familiar with every detail related to Vision 004, but she instinctively felt that the Gravekeeper’s behavior was not quite right. It was very different from what the records described.

But Vanna did not lose her calm. She reminded herself again and again that she was inside a very highly ranked ancient Vision. Here, even the smallest

detail could be a matter of life and death. Because of this, she was extremely cautious and did not dare accept this “extra service” from the Gravekeeper: “I think… I know where to go.”

The Gravekeeper simply fixed his gaze on the “Visitor” in front of him. No emotion showed in his single eye. After a few seconds, he nodded and slowly stepped back: “All right. Please walk straight ahead. When it is over, I will personally escort you out.”

The Gravekeeper’s figure vanished into the corridor.

Vanna stared blankly for a moment and suddenly realized that he had even said “please” and “personally escort you out.”

…Why was this cold, proud ancient Guard so polite today…?

She shook her head and tried hard to push all the messy thoughts out of her mind, afraid that this was some kind of mental disturbance from the ancient Vision. Vanna forced herself to focus on what she should do. At last, she passed through the long corridor and entered the deepest burial chamber of the palace.

Inside the burial chamber, the mysterious headless corpse still sat upright on the tall throne. Pale braziers blazed on both sides. Across from the body of the Nameless King, there was a chair that had clearly been moved there recently.

Vanna’s eyelid twitched.

At that moment, even the always strict and self-disciplined Inquisitor had a rather absurd thought—if she came here again next time, would there be a fruit plate too…

She walked to the chair, sat down carefully, then raised her head and looked at the headless corpse on the throne.

In the next second, Vanna opened her eyes and found herself standing on a vast stone plaza. A chaotic sky covered her vision. In the distance, mysterious light rose from the tops of broken pillars. A rumbling sound came from behind her—Vision 004 was sinking quickly and returning to the underground.

Vanna was still a little dazed, while the Saints waiting on the plaza had already rushed over and gathered around her.

One Saint's phantom carried the familiar presence of Valentine. He came up to Vanna and spoke quickly: "Hurry and see what is written on the parchment sheet."

Only then did Vanna react. She quickly lifted the parchment sheet in her hand.

As expected, this parchment sheet was still incomplete, but compared with last time, when only a little scrap had remained, things were already much better.

The parchment sheet had only been torn in half. Clear writing remained on the other half.

Vanna's gaze swept over the familiar handwriting—

"The Shadows in the dark sea trench have begun to rise.

"The day to set sail.

"Vision Pland."

The Saints looked at each other. Bishop Valentine's phantom raised his head and stared at Vanna in shock. He seemed to want to ask something by instinct, but did not know how to put it into words.

The content on the parchment sheet had a problem. A big problem.

Yet the Listener would not remember her experience in the central burial chamber. The words carried out on the slip of paper were all the information there was. Vision 004 would not answer any extra questions. The only guarantee was that the information on the paper was true and correct.

“The Shadows in the dark sea trench… the day to set sail…” A Saint could not help whispering and looked at his companions in confusion. “The messages that came out of the mausoleum in the past were all fairly clear and direct. It was rare to see such an obscure metaphor…”

“Maybe this is the clear and direct message, and the key part was just torn away,” another Saint muttered. “Compared to that, the last line is…”

“Vision, Pland,” someone said softly.

Vanna’s eyes also locked onto the last line on the slip. Of the three lines, only this one fully caught her attention.

Naturally, she thought of that great fire, that ghost ship, and the Ghost flames that had finally swept across the whole city-state. But right after that, Vanna noticed something else.

“No number…” she said softly in surprise. Then she looked up at Valentine and repeated, “No number?!”

At that moment, she did not even know which point she should be more shocked by first.

Was it that Pland had been defined as a “Vision,” or that this Vision actually had no number at all?

The Saints grew restless. Although they were all high-level Clerics from different regions of the Church, and although they all had firm wills and great power, they still could not help falling into confusion at this moment. Low, uneasy discussions sounded all around. Some Saints who knew them

better came over to Vanna and Valentine to ask about Pland's current situation.

This left Vanna a little at a loss—compared with the skilled and steady Bishop Valentine, she was still too young.

Fortunately, the commotion only lasted a short while. The Saints gathered on the plaza suddenly fell silent. Vanna looked up and saw the hazy shadows moving aside of one accord. An elegant lady in a splendid priest's robe was walking toward her and Bishop Valentine.

Vanna and Valentine bowed at once: "Your Eminence, Pope."

"No need for so much ceremony."

Helena, the Pope, ruler of the Deep Sea Church and the Storm Goddess's voice in the mortal world, let her gaze fall on Vanna and then on the parchment sheet. "May I have a look?"

"Of course," Vanna said at once. She hurried to hand over the parchment sheet. "Here."

Helena took the parchment sheet and let her eyes sweep over the words. Then she raised her head and looked at Vanna with a faint smile. "Your handwriting is very nice—much better than in your reports."

Vanna froze for a moment. She had not expected the Pope to suddenly bring this up, and then she felt a little embarrassed: "That report… I wrote it in a bit of a hurry. The city-state was rather chaotic at the time…"

"Understandable. The first time I had to write such a long report, I almost wanted to swallow my pen," Helena said with a smile. "That is why the typewriter is a good invention. Why not use it?"

Vanna's tone sounded a bit strange: "…I always break them by accident, and I am not used to them either."

Helena’s smile grew broader. Then she handed the parchment sheet back to Vanna and said casually: “I have already read all the reports you submitted about Pland’s historic corruption incident—including the part about the Vanished. To be honest, after such a huge upheaval, it is not surprising that the city-state of Pland has become something like a ‘Vision.’

“Although the birth of this Vision was unusual, being ‘unusual’ is exactly the nature of Anomalies and Visions.”

As Helena spoke, she paused slightly. Her expression slowly grew serious.

“It is just that… having no number is a bit too ‘unusual.’”

Chapter 259: After the Coin Flipped

Ever since Vision 004 delivered the first “list” to the world, every Anomaly and every Vision had its own number. No matter how their locations shifted or their traits changed, even when some Anomalies and Visions vanished and some transformed into each other, there was always a matching slot for them on that list.

For thousands of years, this rule never changed.

Because of this, people believed that Vision 004 was, in essence, a “focus” that crossed the order of time and space. All Anomalies and Visions, whether from the past or from the future, had already left their marks in this focus—even if they had not yet been born. Their positions had long been decided.

Yet today, this rule was broken.

A Vision without a number had appeared before the world.

What was even more disturbing was that this Vision was called “Pland”—the pearl of the Boundless Sea, the busiest stop on the sea trade network, and the largest gathering of believers of the Deep Sea Church.

But for some reason, Vanna kept feeling that the calm and reserved Pope in front of her did not seem very worried. When Helena saw that Pland had become a Vision, she was only a little surprised. She even seemed more

concerned about the fact that “Pland had no number” than about “Pland becoming a Vision” at all.

Vanna looked at the Pope with some nervousness. Helena was thinking about something. After a few minutes of heavy silence that felt almost suffocating, Helena suddenly raised her head: “Since that ‘disaster,’ how has Pland been?”

“Order in the city-state is being restored. Everyone who died because of the historic corruption, and every damaged place, has been restored—of course, that does not include the people who truly died eleven years ago,” Bishop Valentine said at once. “We checked every corner of the city-state, including every sewer, every factory, every machine, and even every pipe. We did not find any trace of supernatural distortion. The city-state is in a… very, very ‘normal’ state. Oh, except for…”

“Except for the matter with the fries, right?” Helena said calmly. “I saw that in the report.”

Vanna looked a little embarrassed: “It did feel a bit strange to write that in the report…”

“Not strange. After an supernatural incident, every clue should be taken seriously,” Helena said, her face calm. Her eyes fell on Vanna. “Then what about you, Saint Vanna—have you felt that anything is wrong?”

Vanna grew nervous without thinking. She had guessed the Pope would ask her this sooner or later. After all, she had written everything in her report, except the part about her shaken faith.

“I… actually do not feel anything special,” Vanna said. “I have no mental corruption, no Cognitive Distortion. Bishop Valentine even helped me run several tests. The conclusion was that it was just a simple ‘connection.’”

Helena gently clenched her fist and rested it under her chin, as if thinking seriously for a moment. Then she suddenly spoke to the Saints gathered nearby: “Everyone, disperse for now—I have some things to discuss with the two Saints from Pland.”

The shadowy figures on the plaza did not hesitate. They all bowed to the Pope and then faded away one after another. In less than half a minute, the vast meeting place held only Helena, Vanna, and Valentine.

“You are a bit nervous, young Saint—relax a little.”

When the area was quiet, Helena turned to Vanna and spoke with a smile. “You walk on the right path. The Goddess’s favor and grace for you remain as always. You do not need to feel uneasy just because you have touched some ‘dangerous’ power. As defenders of order, dealing with all kinds of dangerous powers is exactly our duty, is it not?”

Vanna took a light breath and tried to keep her voice as calm as possible: “…It is just as you say.”

Helena nodded and turned her eyes to Bishop Valentine: “I saw a point mentioned in your reports. You think that the famous ‘Captain Duncan’ has already regained his reason and humanity, and that there is a chance to communicate with him?”

“Strictly speaking, it is not just that there is a chance to communicate. We are already building that communication—though the start of this matter was not in our plan,” Valentine said with a slight nod, his voice deep. “We still do not know why that ghost captain is especially focused on Pland’s situation, and why he chose Vanna as his contact. But up to now, he has not shown any hostility toward the civilized world.”

“The Vanished’s flames once burned across the entire city-state?” Helena asked.

Valentine nodded again: “Yes. Those flames drove out the historic corruption created by the Heretics and reset the city-state to its state before the corruption.”

“…You could also say that those flames corrupted the entire city-state and corrupted it into a state of never having been corrupted.”

Helena fixed her gaze on Valentine’s eyes and spoke in a steady tone: “On this matter, the line between ‘corrupted’ and ‘not corrupted’ is already very blurred.”

Valentine exchanged a glance with Vanna without thinking.

Right after that, they heard Helena’s voice continue: “This may be the reason Pland became a ‘Vision.’ The parchment sheet did not mention the exact traits of this new Vision, but we can boldly describe it like this:

“Vision Pland: a city completely burned by Subspace flame. Duncan Abnomar’s power shaped this Vision into a normal form. Its distortion lies in the fact that it twisted its own distortion. The whole city-state runs as if it had never suffered corruption. The only fact left by the corruption is that the corruption really did happen.”

Helena stopped and quietly set her gaze on the two Saints before her.

“A coin that was heads up flipped once in the air and landed with heads up again.”

Vanna opened her mouth, as if she was about to say something, but then she saw the Pope in front of her wave lightly, cutting her off.

“But there is nothing bad about that, Saint Vanna.” Helena spoke gently. “Compared with the twisted shapes that most places in our world show, what does a coin that is still heads up after it flips even count as?

“At least, in fact, Pland still exists. Whether this coin flipped once or countless times… is not something we mortals should worry about.”

For some reason, Vanna kept feeling that there was some deeper meaning hidden in the Pope’s words, but she still could not understand it. She only frowned: “Then how should we announce this news? How should we explain to people that they live inside a huge Vision—and still let them live normal lives after they learn this fact?”

“A shocking fact born from a great change should either never be announced, or be announced while the echo of that change is still there and people are most able to accept it,” Helena said in a low voice. “Right now, the citizens of Pland should still not be fully out of the shadow of that disaster. They have not fully sunk back into calm daily life… so announce it as usual.

“But pay attention to mental guidance. Let people understand how very special this ‘Vision’ is—not all Visions are dangerous. Always remember, our world has survived to this day because it still lives under the light of Vision 001.”

“Yes,” Bishop Valentine said, lowering his head. “I will discuss this with City Hall and see how to release this news in the safest way.”

Helena nodded. Her eyes swept over Vanna without meaning to, and she said: “There are also some other matters.”

Vanna and Valentine answered at once: “Please give us your orders.”

Helena thought for a moment: “…They are not that urgent. We will talk about them in detail when we meet in person.”

At first Vanna did not react. Two seconds later, she suddenly realized something: “Meet in person… you mean you are going to…?”

“The great Storm Cathedral has sailed around for many years. It is about time for it to come to shore once,” Helena said, smiling at Vanna. “Make some preparations. The great Storm Cathedral will arrive in Pland within a week—then I can use my own eyes to see what shape this coin looks like after it has flipped.”

The two Saints left.

In the vast meeting place, only Helena’s figure remained.

But only half a minute later, faint flickering lights appeared in the nearby darkness. Then Banster, the tall, thin, aged leader of the Death Church, and Rune, the kindly faced and slightly plump head of the Truth Academy, walked out from the dark and came to stand before Helena.

Banster first turned his head to glance in the direction where Vanna had just left. Then he turned his gaze back to the Pope of the Deep Sea: “It is her? She does not… look very special.”

“But the ruler of the storm chose her,” Helena said calmly. “That is the Goddess’s will.”

Rune, with his rounder figure and kind face, thought for a moment. There was curiosity in his voice: “But why would the ruler of the storm choose her?”

“…No one can guess the storm’s intent.” Helena shook her head lightly and then changed the subject. “Let us not talk about that. Let us first discuss the information that Vision 004 released this time—a Vision with no number. That is far more puzzling than the Vision itself.”

Chapter 260: The Cathedral Ark

In the wide, dim assembly hall, the three Church leaders fell silent at the same time.

After who knew how long, the Servitor of the God of Death, Pope Banster, finally spoke softly: “The law of Anomalies and Visions going off pattern – there will always be Anomalies or Visions that do not follow the rules.”

“Clause Zero is indeed useful, but we cannot use Clause Zero recklessly,” the short, plump, kindly Rune shook his head. “We cannot throw Clause Zero at everything we cannot understand. That would numb us when a real danger appears, and we would miss our chance.”

“You mean… the information from Vision 004 has a problem?” Banster tilted his head slightly. “Vision Pland did not actually lack a number. Its number is simply hidden?”

“Or it may be an entirely new naming scheme,” Rune said in thought. “Vision 004 and Vision Pland themselves have no problem. We just cannot yet understand this new way of naming Visions. The things that happened in Pland lately are very unusual. It is a city-state corrupted by history and then ‘saved’ by the power of the Subspace. Nothing like that has ever happened before…”

“I do not like ‘new mechanisms’,” Banster shook his head, his voice low. “New mechanisms mean new factors we cannot control. We have already sacrificed too much to figure out how the world runs… and this world keeps changing.”

“No one likes them, but the world has always been this cold,” Rune shrugged, then his eyes fell on Helena. “I hope you can gain something in Pland. Use your own eyes to see what really happened to that city-state.”

Helena did not speak for a moment. She only nodded lightly. She seemed to fall into thought. After a long time, she suddenly broke the silence: “There is one more thing. You must have noticed it too – the problem with Vision 001.”

Rune’s expression grew serious. This old man who served the God of Wisdom rarely had such a tense face. “Yes. The Sun-Watching Tower has confirmed that the rune ring at the edge of the Sun… really suffered damage. The missing part is only a small piece of the whole rune structure, but that piece is indeed gone. I am still sending people to watch the state of Vision 001 at all times, but so far we have not seen the rune ring break any further – yet there are no signs of it repairing itself either.”

“In all regions, we have not found any unusual moves from the Suntists,” Banster spoke right after. “I also first suspected that this matter was related to them, but from the intelligence we have now, those Sun heretics themselves do not seem to have noticed the change in Vision 001 yet.”

“That still does not prove this has nothing to do with the ‘Creeping Sun Wheel’,” Helena said in a low voice. “The Creeping Sun Wheel is one of the oldest beings in this world, and those Sun heretics at best are only mold growing under its influence. Their connection with their own deity is not as close as they like to believe.”

“We will keep watching those cultists and the ‘Sun spawn’ behind them,” Banster said slowly. “And those Enders as well… No matter what, what happened in Pland must not happen again.”

Helena nodded slightly. Then she saw light and shadow ripple in the darkness as the figures of the two popes grew faint and dissolved into

nothing.

She turned back and glanced at the place where the Nameless King's tomb had sunk. Then her own figure slowly faded from the assembly hall as well.

The next second, Helena opened her eyes in the Mortal Realm.

She stepped out of the secret chamber, and two attendants came forward. Helena waved a hand, signaling the attendants to leave on their own. Then she walked alone through the long corridor toward the upper deck of the Cathedral Ark.

A towering Cathedral sailed across a vast, dim sea. Its three spires and its many tall towers and bell towers pointed straight at the sky, their tops lost in drifting mist. The lower half of the Cathedral Ark was heavy armor, huge pipes, and rough mechanical structures that connected to the deck area.

An ark-like giant ship, its lower half an iron fortress, its upper half a holy Cathedral – this was the true headquarters of the Deep Sea Church, the "Great Storm Cathedral" that patrolled the Boundless Sea.

Helena walked out from a corridor covered in sacred reliefs and stepped onto a terrace on the upper deck. She quietly looked down at the towering wonder of engineering beneath her feet.

This Cathedral was actually quite new. In fact, the hull had been finished only thirty-five years ago, and its upper structures had been completely built just twenty years ago. Scholars from the Academy of Truth helped design the Cathedral Ark's vast power system and complex control mechanisms. At least so far, all of it was running very well.

Before this Cathedral Ark was finished, the Great Storm Cathedral had been much smaller than it was now, and its cruising endurance on the Boundless Sea had been much shorter.

The Storm Goddess did not mind her believers using the help of other faiths to build her holy sanctuary. None of the Four Gods minded such things.

In fact… the Four Gods did not care about anything that happened in the mortal world at all.

Helena took a slow breath and looked at the thin mist around the Cathedral Ark. That veil of mist and the murky, dark texture of the surrounding water showed that the whole ark was sailing in the gap between the Mortal Realm and the Spirit Realm. From this position, most ordinary ships sailing on the Boundless Sea could not see any trace of the Great Storm Cathedral.

After quietly standing in the cold wind for a while, Helena reached out and took from her side a piece of wood that had been carefully carved by hand into the shape of a wave.

She silently recited the name of the Storm Goddess Gamona and threw the wave-shaped charm amulet, carved from “Sea-Breath Wood”, far out into the sea.

“The faith of the Saint you are watching has already begun to waver,” Helena’s divine gaze rested on the spot where the charm amulet hit the water, and she spoke softly, as if to herself. “But her human side does not seem stained – she is still human.”

The waves rose and fell gently. It was as if invisible whispers sounded softly within the murmur of the sea. Helena tilted her head and listened for a long time, then nodded slightly: “So this is good enough… yes, I understand.”

After rolling and bobbing on the surface for a long time, the Sea-Breath Wood charm amulet flipped once and sank silently into the Boundless Sea.

Pland, inside the antique shop.

The morning sunlight was just right. Bright sunlight shone through the freshly wiped shop window onto the shelves of all heights, so that the fake antiques on the shelves seemed to be coated with a faint layer of gold. Nina hummed a cheerful tune in a minor key as she happily wiped the “goods” on the shelves. From time to time she peeked out to look at the few figures by the counter.

Alice and Shirley sat there, frowning over a stack of letter cards. Dog hid in the shadows beside the counter, holding a pencil in his paws and trying to copy the word list from memory.

Nina found it a very strange thing. To this day she still did not understand how Dog managed to hold a pencil with his paws.

After almost falling asleep for the third time, Shirley let out a huge yawn and put the letter cards in her hand down on the counter. She looked up at Alice, who was still completely focused: “Aren’t you sleepy at all?”

“I’m not sleepy,” Alice raised her head and answered honestly. “I don’t know what ‘sleepy’ feels like – I only sleep when it’s time to sleep.”

“…I’m really curious what it feels like to be a doll with a soul,” Shirley muttered. Then she carefully looked around and, like a thief, glanced up toward the second floor before lowering her voice. “Hey, why hasn’t Mr. Duncan come down today… and when I saw him this morning he also looked very preoccupied.”

Alice put aside the letter card she had just memorized, picked up another one she had already forgotten, and started again. Absent-mindedly, she said: “He’s thinking about the secrets in the Deep Sea.”

“Thinking about the secrets in the Deep Sea?” Shirley froze for a moment. “What do you mean?”

“I don’t know. That’s what he said,” Alice gave a small shake of her head. “Why don’t you go ask him? He should be happy to teach you a few things…”

Shirley opened her mouth and was just about to say something when she suddenly heard Dog’s panicked voice coming from the shadows beside the counter: “If you want to get yourself killed, don’t drag me along!”

“I never said I was going to ask,” Shirley glared in the direction of the voice. “I haven’t even finished my alphabet yet…”

She had only said half the sentence when a crisp jingle of a brass bell suddenly sounded from the door.

Dog vanished without a trace at once. Alice smoothly set the letter cards aside and looked up toward the door: “Welcome. May I… Eh? Mr. Morris?”

It was Morris who had come so early in the morning. The old scholar wore a dark winter coat and a thick bowler hat, and tucked under his arm was a hefty-looking old book. After he came in, he first greeted Alice and Shirley by the counter, then looked toward Nina, who was tidying the shelves nearby: “Is Mr. Duncan here?”

“He’s upstairs,” Nina nodded, looking curiously at the old gentleman. “Do you need something from him?”

“I think I’ve found the origin of that symbol,” Morris said happily, lifting the old book he had brought. “It’s unbelievable. It actually appeared in a document about the ancient kingdom of Critt – and in such an inconspicuous place!”

Chapter 261: The Mysterious Symbol

Nina was just about to run upstairs to call him when Duncan appeared on the stairs.

He had heard the noise from downstairs.

“Mr. Duncan,” Morris came to the foot of the stairs and looked up at the “captain” who was gazing down. “I found that symbol you showed me in a document on the ancient kingdom of Critt… or at least something very close to it.”

Duncan noticed the faint bloodshot in Morris’s eyes and his slightly swollen eyelids. Clearly, the old scholar had put in a great deal of effort to find these materials. Yet there was also a trace of excited light in Morris’s eyes, and his spirit seemed abnormally bright. It was the look one only had when deep in research and finally gaining results.

Duncan glanced at Nina, Alice, and the others downstairs and gave a small nod: “You look after the shop.”

Then he looked at Morris: “Come upstairs and tell me.”

The old gentleman, still clutching the big book, stepped onto the stairs. The old wooden steps creaked under his feet. He followed Duncan to the master bedroom on the second floor – this was his first time in this place.

By the standards of a dwelling for a Subspace shadow, this bedroom seemed a bit plain. But considering Mr. Duncan’s special “hobby” of

playing the mortal, this simple room actually looked quite normal.

Morris carefully controlled his movements, satisfying his curiosity without making any extra probing. Duncan pulled over two chairs from the side and motioned for the old gentleman to put the big book on the desk by the window.

“Tell me what you found,” Duncan said after he sat down. “What does that symbol actually stand for?”

“As for its meaning… I still have no clue for now. I only found what is most likely its source,” Morris steadied himself, opened the valuable-looking volume, and turned to a page marked with a bookmark. “Do you see this spot? It appears here.”

Duncan frowned slightly. On that page was a picture, a finely drawn hand illustration showing part of a large building that looked like the main gate of a palace. The symbol with the hexagonal frame and the shattered cross structure appeared in the relief above the gate, at the very center of the whole image.

As for the content of the relief itself… it seemed to be just patterns whose meaning could not be seen.

Just as Morris had said downstairs, the symbol was in a very inconspicuous place. It was only a small decorative detail in the illustration, taking up less than a tenth of the whole picture, and it had not been specially marked.

It was really impressive that Morris could find this book among piles of documents and then find this tiny corner inside it.

“I had a vague impression of it, like something I glimpsed a very long time ago. Thanks to the divine blessing of the God of Wisdom, that ‘impression’ could still work today and let me find this ‘little thing’,” Morris explained. “This illustration is a copy. Its original first appeared in a study on

architectural ruins of the ancient kingdom of Critt. That document is not in Pland at the moment, but I believe some of my friends in the academic circles can help a bit…”

“Of course, even without the original, the material recorded in this book is still very useful. It says that this hand illustration shows a lost ruin that once stood in the border seas. The ruin was on a nameless barren island, and that island mysteriously vanished into a thick fog around New City-State Calendar year 223. Before it vanished completely, several expeditions managed to land there and examined the form and age of the ruins. They confirmed it was a product of the ancient kingdom era of Critt. Judging from the surface patterns and reliefs on the buildings, the whole facility should have been some large complex with both academic and religious meaning…”

As Morris spoke, he pointed to the written description on the page next to the illustration. On the slightly yellowed pages, Duncan could see notes the old scholar had written years ago.

“Reliefs with hard, deep lines and the large number of diamond shapes in the patterns are features of the architecture of the ancient kingdom of Critt. They favored heavy lines and a style that felt powerful. The main bodies of their palaces and buildings were mostly various rectangular prisms or pyramid shapes. This structure fits those features perfectly…”

As he listened to Morris’s explanation, Duncan slowly let his gaze move over the pictures and the lines of text. His attention returned to the hexagonal pattern at the center of the relief above the main gate, and his brows furrowed slightly: “There is no specific explanation about this symbol.”

“…Sadly, this document is only a general introduction. It does not go into detailed analysis of every detail in the ruin,” Morris shook his head. “But

that is only to be expected. The ancient kingdom of Critt is ten thousand years in the past. The ruins it left are few and mostly badly damaged. Add to that the loss or ‘corruption’ of all kinds of materials, and the knowledge left for later generations to study is already fragmented. It would be very hard to find an article written just to study some pattern on a single gate from that ancient kingdom…”

“An academic or religious facility, a badge at the entrance…” Duncan rubbed his chin in thought. “Why would a group of ‘ascetics’ living ten thousand years later carry a charm amulet from the ancient kingdom era of Critt?”

He turned his head and looked at Morris. “Do you think it is possible that there are ‘Critt descendants’ who have passed down a bloodline for ten thousand years?”

“…Someone once said that a careful scholar should not blindly deny any possibility, no matter how small the chance. But from my own point of view, I really think this is impossible.”

Morris spoke cautiously while thinking.

“A group like those ascetics, likely very few in number and acting in extreme secrecy, would have had to survive the great chaos after the fall of the ancient kingdom, live through the Age of Strife and the old city-state wars, and pass their line down for a full ten thousand years without ever breaking and without being discovered… If that possibility is true, then I would rather believe they are a secret cult founded only in recent times. They may have happened to discover some ancient documents or similar ruins and then took some symbol from the Critt period as their own mark. That possibility is still higher.”

Duncan listened to the old gentleman’s thoughts and only gave a noncommittal grunt, then let his eyes move over the lines of text again.

In the material, some passages were clearly quotations from the original document. They recorded the scattered words left by the explorers who had gone there more than a thousand years ago:

“…It stands in the center of the island. The main building and its surrounding annexes almost fill the whole island. It feels as if the island exists only for this structure…”

“…The main material of the structure looks like stone, but it is tougher than stone, with a pale color. A soldier tried to chip off one of the wall bricks with an ice axe and only succeeded after using great force… When the axe struck the brick it gave off exaggerated sparks, and the broken surface of the brick had a silver-gray sheen.

“There are several small islands near the main one, all very desolate. The plants are sparse, and even insects are rarely seen… There are no remains of any buildings. Perhaps there were some once, but they were too small and have been eaten by time…

“…On the evening of the third day, while the launch circled the island, we found that a collapsed section which had been above the water was somehow already submerged, yet there was no sign of a rising tide… Fog began to gather over the nearby sea. The priest had a bad feeling. After offering benediction to the God of Death Bartok and seeking revelation, he advised that we leave the island at once.”

Duncan looked straight at the end of this quotation and saw that the author of the document had recorded this:

“On the seventh day after this expedition withdrew, the thick fog cleared. Another team reached that sea area, but could no longer find the nameless island.”

Duncan could not help feeling a little regret.

“So it was swallowed by the fog just like that…” he sighed softly. “It sounds like the result of a border collapse.”

“It does look that way – but back then, the Holy beacon technology had not yet matured, and there were no precise means of observation. Several Anomaly phenomena, including border collapse and the ‘fog-eating’ phenomenon, were very easy to mix up.”

“The Fog-Eating Phenomenon…” Duncan searched his memory for a moment and found the relevant knowledge. He had been cramming this kind of common sense from books recently. “If it really was the Fog-Eating Phenomenon, then this island might briefly show itself again in similar thick fog later. But it seems no records of that sort were ever passed down.”

“That’s true. But it’s also possible the related records were simply lost.”

Duncan made a sound in response and, almost without thinking, let his fingers brush over the illustration, over the tiny shattered cross mark on it.

“In this drawing… there shouldn’t be any chance that the copyist ‘added things as he liked’, right?” he asked suddenly, uneasy.

“I don’t think so,” Morris answered at once. “This is very rigorous academic material. The artist who drew the illustration and the scholar who compiled the original document were both respected authorities known for their care. When they left these records, they would rather leave unclear parts as they were for later generations than make ‘extra touches’ without evidence. Or, to put it another way, even if they did make adjustments, they would certainly explain the situation in the notes.”

“So it can be trusted as real…”

Duncan murmured this softly, lost in thought.

Chapter 262: Captain Duncan’s Gift

In the hefty volume that Morris had brought, only a tiny section had anything to do with that mysterious symbol. Even there, the symbol was just a very inconspicuous detail. The author of the document did not spend a single word explaining the symbol or the relief patterns around it.

Duncan and Morris could only analyze the details shown in the manuscript’s illustrations. They tentatively decided that the Shattered Cross enclosed in a hexagonal outline was a religious symbol, or an academic emblem, from the Ancient Kingdom Era.

Duncan slowly closed the big book.

From a rational point of view, Morris judged that the ascetics who had visited the Vanished a century ago could not be descendants of the Ancient Kingdom. The chance that a group of hermits had kept a ten-thousand-year lineage alive through the chaotic, dangerous era of the Deep Sea was almost zero. From a strict academic standpoint, he could not make that kind of assumption without more evidence.

Yet Duncan still felt, on instinct, that those ascetics had to be closely connected to the ancient kingdom of Critt. They held that mysterious badge and treasured it, which meant they knew what it signified.

Of course, a guess was only a guess. Without evidence, it was all empty talk. For now, unless that group of ascetics appeared before Duncan again, no one would ever figure out where they came from.

Duncan suddenly looked up and asked: “How many Critt ruins that have been found and are still preserved reasonably well are left in the world now?”

“There are very, very few ruins that have been found. You can count them on one hand. As for those that are preserved ‘well’… that depends on what you mean by ‘well’,” Morris said. “For people who study the Ancient Kingdom, finding a big pit that can be confirmed to be related to Critt, or finding wall bricks more than ten meters long still joined together, or even just a few stone doors fallen on the ground, all of that already counts as being preserved very well.”

At this point, the old scholar could not help letting out a soft sigh: “Under normal circumstances, ruins left within a city-state’s territory almost never survive. We do our best to keep written and visual records of them, to describe and record every tiny detail. Then we store any objects that can be studied inside research facilities. In the end… the ruins themselves are leveled, filled in, and turned into part of the city.”

Duncan thought for a moment and murmured to himself: “Land you can stand on is as precious as gold.”

Morris nodded: “We study history. We preserve history. We try to remember what came before as the years pass. But we cannot let the things of the past squeeze out the space we need to live.

“The New City-State Calendar has almost reached two thousand years. In the days when explorers were most active, new islands were still being discovered, and unknown wilderness and ancient ruins kept entering our sight. But in the last one or two centuries, such ‘discoveries’ have almost vanished.

“The ‘new islands’ from back then slowly turned into one city-state after another. There is only so much land to stand on in the Boundless Sea. The

few ruins that are left are either on lonely islands where people cannot survive because the environment is too harsh, or they are covered by supernatural forces, or they sit on the edge of dangerous Visions. Even the Four Gods Church can only survey such places a little and then seal them away on the enchanted sea chart."

Duncan stayed silent for a long time, but his attention still fell back on that symbol and the primary document behind it. He asked: "You just said a friend of yours in academia might be able to find more material related to this symbol?"

Morris nodded: "I have a friend in Lunsa who specializes in the history of the Ancient Kingdom. He was my classmate when I studied further at the Truth Institute." Morris pointed at the big book on the table. "He gave me this book many years ago. I remember he also mentioned some related documents back then. I have already written to him, but I do not know when his reply will come."

Duncan let out a breath: "Then we will wait patiently. Let things follow their own course."

After that, he and Morris talked about many more things related to the ancient kingdom of Critt: about those scattered discoveries, those vague and strange legends, those half-true, half-false ancient scrolls that made it impossible to tell whether they belonged to the Mortal Realm or to pure myth.

After this long and pleasant talk between host and guest, it was time for Morris to say goodbye and leave.

"When I left, I promised my wife I would go home for lunch," the old scholar said with a smile on his face. "If I go back too late, I am afraid my wife and my daughter will scold me together for half the day."

Duncan could not help laughing: “It sounds to me like you enjoy it.”

Morris nodded cheerfully, put on his hat, tucked the big book under his arm, and went downstairs with Duncan.

Nina was behind the counter, counting a few banknotes. Alice watched curiously beside her. Shirley had vanished at some point, probably run out to play.

As Duncan came down the stairs, Nina was patiently teaching the clueless Alice about money: “Look, this one with the golden corner mark is a Sola. Here is the face value… These coins are ‘Peso’. The number on the front is the value… And you must not bite them, they are dirty!”

Duncan glanced at the money in Nina’s hand and raised his eyebrows slightly: “Looks like business was decent today. We usually do not have this much.”

“Yes, I don’t know why, but business was really good today,” Nina said happily, waving the banknotes at Duncan. “It seems to have something to do with Alice?”

Duncan froze when he heard that: “Has something to do with Alice?”

“That was what an old madam said when she left just now,” Nina said with a squinting smile. “She said the shop had gained a shop assistant who looked just like the young miss, and it made all the things on the shelves seem real.”

Duncan: “…?”

He silently looked at Alice. Alice stared back at him in confusion.

However, the doll had no idea what was happening. She was still trying hard to remember what the banknotes looked like and to learn how to count money.

“I really did not expect Alice to be able to have this kind of effect here,” Duncan remarked after a while, sounding thoughtful. Then he suddenly turned to Morris: “Do you want to take something with you when you go back?”

“Ah?” Morris was a little surprised. “I… did not have that in mind when I went out…”

“No charge. Think of it as my thanks for your work in searching for the documents,” Duncan said with a smile. He walked over to the counter, reached up to the shelf, and took down a crystal pendant. It was exactly the same as the one he had given Morris earlier as a “free gift”, because he had bought a full crate of this kind of pendant when he stocked the shop. “I remember you mentioned that your daughter’s pendant was damaged. I will give you this one.”

Morris looked at the pendant in Duncan’s hand. The beautiful crystal, a product of modern industry, swung lightly in the air, its surface reflecting shifting lights. Yet the first thing that came to his mind was the incredible story Heidi had told him after she came back:

how she had stayed clear-headed while the city-state crumbled, how she had watched two threads of history split and one of them be wiped out, and how she had been protected by the Amulet.

Only now did he slowly realize that Captain Duncan had already offered his goodwill back then.

That dagger worth three thousand four hundred Sola had been only a trivial gift. The real treasure had almost been overlooked right before his eyes.

Duncan smiled and said: “I hope this charm amulet can keep bringing Miss Heidi good luck. Take it. You have earned it.”

Morris reached out solemnly to take the crystal pendant and thanked him. But Duncan seemed to think of something again and muttered, looking thoughtful: “If you only take this pendant back, your daughter will definitely nag you again, and this time your lady will join in. Wait a moment. I will find you something real so you can explain yourself properly to your wife and child when you get home.”

As soon as Morris heard that, he waved his hands again and again: “No need, no need, you really do not have to do this for me…”

But Duncan had already turned away and started rummaging through the pile of odds and ends beside the counter. He did not even look up as he muttered: “No need to say more, I understand… Ah, found it.”

As he spoke, he came back to the counter carrying the “real thing” he had found and dropped it onto the countertop with a heavy bang.

The sudden noise made Alice jump. She quickly reached up to hold her head.

Morris stared, dumbfounded, at the item Duncan had placed on the counter.

“This is…” The old gentleman did not quite understand.

“An antique,” Duncan said with a straight face, looking at the old gentleman in front of him. “There are not many genuine items in my shop, but this one is absolutely authentic.”

“It looks like a cannonball?”

“Yes. From the Vanished. The condition is excellent. If you found a muzzle-loading smoothbore with the right caliber, you could even fire it,” Duncan said happily, patting the big iron ball on the counter. “More importantly, the shell still has the full foundry stamp and the caster’s personal mark on it. Honestly, it is even rarer than that dagger from last time. It is yours.”

Morris looked at the shell, then at Duncan, his expression growing stranger and stranger. For a moment, he truly did not know whether bringing home a cannonball or a glass pendant would be more likely to raise his wife and daughter's blood pressure. But faced with Mr. Duncan's warm, eager smile, he swallowed all his words in the end and calmly accepted this… "gift".

"Thank you… very much for your kindness."

Chapter 263: The Knock

Morris left, still wearing a strange look, carrying a cannonball that had a hundred years of history.

Duncan stood behind the counter and watched the old gentleman's back as he left, a pleased smile on his face.

"You really gave the cannonball to Mr. Morris," Alice muttered beside him.

"You really gave the cannonball to Teacher Morris…" Nina muttered after her.

"I do not like cannonballs," Alice whispered. "I especially do not like them."

Nina asked curiously: "Why?"

Alice said with a very serious face: "Because the captain once gave me eight cannonballs…"

"Stop bringing that up," Duncan's voice suddenly came from the side. He looked helplessly at the resentful Alice and at Nina, whose curiosity was clearly stirred. "Where did Shirley go?"

"She said reciting the alphabet was making her dizzy and she needed to go out and get some fresh air," Nina said, sticking out her tongue. "But I guess by now she has already run off to the next street."

"As expected," Duncan sighed. "With Shirley's level of education and personal manners, it is already amazing that she manages not to swear in front of me every day…"

As he spoke, he turned his head to look out the window. Through the clear shopfront glass, the everyday, peaceful street scene of Pland came into view.

People bustled along the road. The citizens busied themselves with their own lives. The Lower City was still quiet today. The brief malfunction of Visions 001, the tiny chip in the Sun's rune ring that was almost invisible to the naked eye, the Deep Dive operation in the far north that people had already forgotten, the mysterious symbol left by the ancient kingdom of Critt… all of it seemed very far away from this sunlit street.

He narrowed his eyes slightly. After a long time, he murmured to himself: "So Tyrian really is going back early…"

…

At the harbor southeast of the city-state, the huge ironclad warship the Sea Mist was already ready to set sail.

After only a few days of "self-recovery", the warship that had once been badly damaged by the Vanished had now mostly healed. The many wounds and cracks on her armored belt and deck had completely closed, leaving not even a trace of damage. The Undying sailors hurried back and forth between the pier and the ship, carrying aboard the supplies and farewell gifts that Pland had generously provided.

The tall Vanna arrived at the pier to personally see off the captain of the Sea Mist.

"We did not expect you to leave so soon," Vanna said. "The Archbishop was ready for the Sea Mist to stay as our guest for at least two weeks."

Tyrian rubbed his forehead lightly: "I also thought I would stay here for a long time… but some accidents happened. There are some matters in the north that I have to go back and deal with."

This sounded like only an excuse, but Vanna had no interest in digging into the parts others did not want to say. She just looked at Tyrian with some concern, her brows knitting slightly: “Forgive my rudeness… Captain, is your face swollen?”

“A small accident, just a small accident.” Tyrian quickly waved his hand. Inwardly he thought that it was lucky he had had another day to recover. If this Inquisitor had seen him yesterday, he really would not have known how to explain a head that had grown a whole size larger.

Then, as if to keep the awkwardness from dragging on, he hurriedly changed the subject: “My days as a guest in Pland were very pleasant, and I am grateful for your gifts.”

“As long as you like them,” Vanna said with a smile, nodding. Then she looked up with some curiosity at the towering side of the Sea Mist and at the main gun turrets visible from the side. “I had heard about it, but seeing it with my own eyes still feels unbelievable… This ship really ‘healed’ just like that, and even those main guns that had been completely erased have… ‘grown back’?”

Tyrian looked back at his warship. His gaze fell on the three new main guns that had clearly just regrown and still looked a little smaller than the others. A proud smile appeared on his face: “The Sea Mist knows what it is supposed to look like. It always tends to keep itself in the best condition. But those main guns still cannot really be used yet. They are still small. They need to grow for a few more days before they can fire full-charge, standard-caliber shells like the other guns.”

Vanna stared for a moment. She kept feeling that there was something wrong with the way he smiled at his ship’s main guns and the tone he used when he spoke about them, but she could not tell what exactly was wrong…

Luckily, she was not the kind of person who would get stuck on such details.

At three twenty in the afternoon, accompanied by a long, deep whistle of steam, the ironclad warship with its towering bow slowly picked up speed and left the city-state.

Vanna stood on the pier and watched the warship until it slowly turned into an unremarkable black speck on the horizon. Only then did she let out a soft breath, turn around, and get into the black steam car that had been waiting nearby for a long time.

The subordinate in charge of driving lifted his head and glanced at the weary look on the Inquisitor's face in the rearview mirror: "You seem very tired?"

"Things keep coming one after another. Paperwork takes far more effort than fighting heretics with a greatsword," Vanna said as she rolled her shoulders and neck, then slumped down in the back seat without any concern for her image. "And I have also been suffering from insomnia lately."

The steam core gave off a low vibration and hum. Gears and connecting rods began to move briskly. Listening to his commander's complaints, the subordinate could not help smiling: "But at least the city-state has been peaceful lately. No heretics, no monsters, no unlucky people trapped in the veil of night. The Guardians on night patrol have not run into any twisted phenomena inside the veil of night for several days in a row… There is always sunshine after a storm, right?"

Vanna listened to the subordinate's sigh and, after a while, said slowly: "Indeed. The nights lately have been calmer than ever. Even in the Lower City, where the darkness usually hangs the heaviest, and in the sewers, no noises have come from there anymore."

“Isn’t that a good thing?”

“…Of course it is a good thing,” Vanna said softly. Then she shifted her posture on the seat and closed her eyes: “I will take a short nap first. Wake me when we get to the Cathedral.”

“Yes.”

By the time the subordinate answered, Vanna already felt herself slipping into a drowsy, light sleep. The mechanical sounds of the car and the noises outside the windows slowly faded away.

She really was very tired. She had not rested properly for many days.

Order in the city-state had fully returned. All the follow-up work was moving towards its end in an orderly way. The paperwork was finished. The reports to the Cathedral and all the contacts with City Hall had gone smoothly. And behind this “everything going well” lay days and days of exhaustion.

After sending off the Sea Mist, this special “Visitor”, she could finally relax a little.

At least before the Storm Cathedral arrived in Pland and before she had to receive His Eminence the Pope, she should be able to rest for a few days.

A soft night breeze suddenly brushed across her cheek, carrying a faint cool and fresh scent. Along with it came the sound of waves beating against a ship’s hull.

Vanna snapped her eyes open.

She now found herself in a strange room.

Everything she saw was elegant, classical decoration. Gorgeous tapestries hung on the walls, their style like something from the last century. Dark-colored shelves and a wine cabinet stood in the corners. A thick woven

carpet covered the center of the room. On the carpet sat a carved sitting table and high-backed chairs, and right now she was sitting in one of those chairs.

Vanna sprang to her feet, then bent her body slightly like a beast about to fight, keeping watch on everything around her.

The next second, she saw the window not far away. The window stood open. When she had fallen asleep it had still been daytime, but now the scene outside showed the veil of night hanging low. The chilly night wind blew in through the window. A cold, clear light spread across the windowsill. In that light she could faintly see the rolling surface of the distant sea and the shimmering reflections on the waves.

The gleam was fine and broken, like quicksilver.

Vanna's gaze fell on the scene outside without her willing it. Then she seemed to notice something, rushed to the window, and lifted her head to look at the sky.

Something… something she could hardly understand appeared there.

It was a glowing round object. It looked like the main body in the center of the Sun, but it was neither dazzling nor burning. Instead, it hung quietly in the sky like a glowing disk that carried a hint of coolness. Faint patterns could be seen on its surface. The whole glowing orb seemed to give off a strange feeling of peace and stillness.

Vanna stared blankly at the eerie glowing orb. For a moment she felt as if her own thoughts had sunk into stillness along with that clear light. Her mind stayed blank for an unknown length of time before a sluggish question finally rose in her head: "What was that?"

Was that the Sun cooled down?

Where had the World's Wound gone?

Then she drew back her gaze and looked around this strange room again.

Where was this place?

Outside was a rolling sea. Around her was a room she did not know. Outside the window was a bizarre sky and a bizarre celestial body. Thinking about everything she had gone through in these last days, the answer did not seem hard to guess.

But this time felt different from before. This time… she did not see that terrifying ghost captain.

Vanna thought this, but as if to answer her thought, in the next second she suddenly felt a presence draw near.

“Knock, knock, knock.”

Someone knocked on the door.

Chapter 264: The Captain’s Warning

To be fair, Vanna had hardly been afraid of anything in her whole life, but Captain Duncan Abnomar always seemed able to bring her all kinds of “unexpected situations”.

The room was sealed inside a dream. Outside the window stretched a boundless dark sea. A strange glowing orb hung high in the sky, and under the silent veil of night, someone knocked on the door.

Vanna almost reacted on instinct. She wanted to call her greatsword into the dream and leap toward the doorway with a heavy chop. Luckily, she held back that impulse at the last second.

“Knock, knock, knock.”

The knocking kept coming, unhurried and steady, full of patience and politeness.

Vanna took several deep breaths. She had no idea what kind of expression she should be wearing, so she simply kept her face tense and tried to make her voice sound normal: “Please come in.”

With a soft click, the handle turned. The dark wooden door was pushed open from outside. A very tall, imposing figure appeared before Vanna and stepped into the room.

Behind that figure there was only pure darkness, like the very edge of the dream—and beyond that edge, nothing at all existed, only void.

Duncan walked into the room and gave Vanna a friendly smile: “Good afternoon, Vanna—this time I did knock.”

Vanna said nothing. She just watched the ghost captain walk in. She watched him go to the liquor cabinet by himself, take out a bottle and two glasses, then slowly walk to the table and sit down in one of the armchairs.

“Not coming over to sit?” Duncan raised his eyebrows and glanced at the young Inquisitor still standing by the window. He gestured toward the empty seat across from him. “The look on your face is not very good.”

Vanna hesitated for a moment, then finally walked over with a strange expression. She sat down carefully while watching him pour the drink. After a long pause, she sighed: “Do you not think this is actually even more frightening?”

“Is it?” Duncan looked at Vanna with some surprise. Then he glanced around at the dream he had spent quite a while setting up—the warm, everyday furniture, and the glass in his hand that was meant to show friendliness. Not very sure of himself, he frowned. “Then next time I can try a brighter color scheme…”

“I do not think it is a color problem…” Vanna felt even her eyebrows twitch. But then something came to mind, and she sighed with a helpless little smile. “All right, at least I can tell I really did feel your ‘goodwill’… This goodwill is a bit scary, but I can more or less believe it is real.”

Duncan pushed a glass toward her: “Sounds like a good thing.”

“Thank you.” Vanna took the glass and looked at the clear liquid with its faint golden?red tint. She hesitated for a long time, then set it aside for now. After that she raised her eyes and looked at the captain across from her: “This is another dream—is this one of the rooms on the Vanished?”

“It is based on one of them, but not completely. I arranged it according to my own taste,” Duncan said slowly. “I am actually not very good at Dreamweaving. I prefer to enter an existing dream directly. But you were sleeping very uneasily. Your dreams were broken and chaotic, so I prepared a place where you can rest properly.”

Vanna did not care much about Duncan’s last sentence. She turned her head to glance out the window and asked the biggest question in her mind: “That glowing thing in the sky outside… what is it? Is that also one of your ‘personal tastes’?”

Duncan fell silent for a moment. His gaze turned to the window. Under the pale light he stayed quiet for a long time before he sighed softly and shook his head: “You can say that. I do not really like the pale, icy glow of the World’s Wound. It is not gentle, and it feels full of malice. As for what you see now… you can call it the ‘Moon’.”

“‘Moon’…” Vanna slowly repeated the strange word that sounded like it was taken straight from some unknown language. “That is a very awkward name to say.”

“You are interested in it?” Duncan looked at Vanna with a faint, amused smile. “Then I can tell you the story behind that name…”

Before he even finished, Vanna shivered all over and sat up straight: “No! Thank you!”

“…All right, it is always like this.” Duncan shrugged, not really bothered. “They are only very ordinary things. They have nothing at all to do with Subspace.”

“Sorry. I do believe you are very friendly, but… just think of me as cowardly,” Vanna said awkwardly. After so many meetings and the chain of events they had gone through, her wariness and guarded attitude toward this

ghost captain had already changed quite a bit without her noticing. But even so, from a logical, rational point of view, Vanna still did not dare to listen lightly to ‘knowledge’ coming from the mouth of this man who had returned from Subspace. “Let us talk about something else instead. Why did you come to me?”

“Two things.” Duncan met Vanna’s eyes with his gaze. “First, I want to thank you all for taking care of Tyrian these last two days. It seems he had a rather pleasant stay in Pland.”

“Captain Tyrian?” Vanna’s heart jumped. She suddenly realized something. “So you have been watching this whole time…”

“Yes, I have been watching this matter,” Duncan said, his tone full of feeling. “He wandered in the north for many years and picked up bad pirate habits. Most of the time he only has a group of undying sailors for company. His social habits are very unhealthy. And because of that old business in Frostholm, you cannot help worrying about his mental state. To keep him from turning into a reclusive, bitter cynic, he needs some healthy and orderly relationships…”

Duncan was basically just making things up as he spoke. He only wanted to further shape his image as someone who had “regained humanity, reason, and clarity”, so it would be easier to deal with Vanna and the “orderly civilization” behind her. But Vanna did not take this as nonsense. She sat there stunned, listening to this ghost captain ramble like an old Father lecturing his child. After a long while she finally squeezed out a sentence: “You… actually care about him a lot…”

Duncan stayed serious: “Family members caring for each other is the first step to maintaining harmony in the family.”

“…But you almost blew the Sea Mist into a pile of scrap iron,” Vanna reminded him carefully.

Duncan kept the same serious face: “Proper discipline and mental guidance are the second step.”

Vanna: “…”

Weird, off, and full of strangeness—Vanna felt more and more that her conversation with Captain Duncan was filled with an indescribable sense of oddness. Yet somehow, in the middle of this strange and mismatched talk, she truly felt… that this ghost captain was becoming more “flesh and blood”.

She had to shake her head and push this sudden thought aside for now: “Then what is the second thing you mentioned?”

“The second thing,” Duncan straightened his expression and became a little more serious, “is about the Sun—have you noticed the change in it?”

At some point, the sound of the waves outside the window had grown quieter, like distant murmurs. The breeze blowing into the room also became faint and thin.

When she heard him mention the Sun, Vanna’s eyes changed a little: “Do you mean the sunrise that was delayed by fifteen minutes, or…”

“The outer rune ring. There is a gap in it,” Duncan said. “From the look on your face, you all noticed it too.”

Vanna stayed silent for two or three seconds, then nodded lightly: “It is hard not to notice. Even though it is a flaw barely visible to the naked eye, for thousands of years there have always been watchful eyes on the running of Vision 001. The Church noticed this disturbing change at once.”

“The Guardians never relax… that makes my opinion of you a bit better,” Duncan said, then suddenly asked, “What do you all think about it?”

“…That depends on what feedback the Storm Cathedral gives,” Vanna replied in a strict, by?the?book tone. “Here in Pland, we can only report what we have observed. We are not a research facility, and we cannot think of any way to intervene in the running of Vision 001.”

She paused to think, then shook her head slightly, not very sure: “Maybe even the Storm Cathedral will not give any clear feedback. Vision 001… its running affects the whole world, and its abnormal state has alarmed more than just the Deep Sea Church.”

While she spoke, Vanna seemed to realize something and raised her head to look at Duncan: “You suddenly came to talk to me about this. Does that mean you know something? Do you know what went wrong with Vision 001?”

Duncan did not answer right away.

He could not help recalling that short, strange dream he had once had.

In that dream, gigantic glowing orbs fell like a meteor shower. The whole world slowly sank into darkness. In the sky there was only terrifying, dreadful darkness left, shaped like a hollow… or like a dying eyeball.

At the time, he had not understood anything from that dream. But now it felt as if he had glimpsed a trace of a prophetic vision in it.

“Even I cannot be sure, Vanna,” he finally broke the silence and calmly met Vanna’s eyes again, his gaze steady. “But I think this is only the beginning.”

A chill slowly spread across her back. Vanna felt she had seen something extremely disturbing in his eyes: “Only the beginning?”

“I still do not have enough proof, but I suspect that Vision 001 actually has a ‘service life’,” Duncan said solemnly. “What the ancient kingdom of Critt left to later generations was not an eternal shelter, but only temporary peace. The Sun above our heads… is very likely about to break down.

“As for when the proof of this will arrive…”

Duncan paused for a moment, then said slowly:

“Maybe huge fragments will fall from the sky, and that will be the ticking of the countdown.

“More likely, the first fragment has already fallen, only it fell outside the sight of the civilized world.”

Cold and unease spread in her heart. Vanna lowered her eyes a little to hide all the changes in them. Her hand slowly picked up the glass beside her, and she raised it to her lips without thinking, as if she wanted to use the alcohol to steady her mood.

She took a sip, frowned a little, and looked up at Duncan: “There is no taste…”

“Of course there is no taste,” Duncan laughed and raised his glass to her in a small toast. “Because you are about to wake up.”

Vanna’s eyes flew open.

She was still sitting in the moving steam car. The tall tower and main building of the Cathedral had appeared in her view.

She panted slightly and heard her subordinate’s voice coming from the front: “Ah, you are awake. Perfect timing, we are almost at the Cathedral.”

Chapter 265: The Sea Witch and the Frontier Relic

A faint golden light spread out and covered the entire sea, filling every part of the space around the Radiant Star.

This oddly shaped magic warship sailed forward wrapped in light. The front half of the hull was running at full power. The paddle wheels on both sides thundered. Many magic devices fixed on the deck kept projecting flickering light grids into the air around them. These devices, all designed personally by the Sea Witch, kept scanning the surroundings during the voyage to collect important data.

The back half of the ship was hazy like mist. It looked like the phantom hull of a ghost ship, sometimes solid, sometimes almost transparent. The ghostly structure faded in and out with the rise and fall of the surrounding light. Many ghost?like sailors moved about on that half?transparent deck. They watched the depth of the Spirit Realm while making sure the Radiant Star itself stayed stable.

The crew on the front half and the back half of the ship were clearly divided. Each group had its own work and only talked or moved between the two sides when it was necessary.

Lucretia stood at the very front of the ship, on the top deck that was in its “blooming” state. This place was like an open terrace. It had the best view on the whole ship and let her see the state of the sea very clearly.

Two thick chains extended from the middle of the Radiant Star. They stretched back over the gently heaving sea and wrapped around a huge stone sphere floating dozens of meters behind the stern.

That stone sphere floated several meters above the surface of the sea. It looked weightless, yet the creaking of the chains from time to time, and the fact that the Radiant Star was moving very slowly even with its power at full output, both proved that dragging this thing was far from easy.

Lucretia watched that stone sphere for a long time before pulling her gaze back and rubbing her eyes.

The endless halo around the stone sphere was not actually harsh on the eyes, but staying under this boundless radiance for a long time still made them a bit uncomfortable. The mysterious bumps and grooves on the surface of the stone sphere were even more dizzying if she stared at them for too long.

Aside from this slight dizziness, however, the stone sphere and the surrounding light mist seemed to have no other harm. Looking at them with a gaze did not damage the mind, and moving closer did not bring any eerie, terrifying whispers. For a strange relic picked up on the frontier, this was very unusual.

Lucretia had wandered on the frontier for many years. She had seen many things that could easily lead mortals into madness. Compared to those, this stone sphere that projected gigantic geometric illusions was truly the safest oddity among all the Frontier Relics.

Footsteps came from the side, and the voice of the clockwork automaton Lunie sounded: “Mistress, there is a report from the boiler room. The engine power cannot be increased any more. This is already the top speed.”

“…Not even one third of our normal cruising speed,” Lucretia sighed. “This big ball looks like it is just floating, but dragging it is really this hard.”

“It is very strange,” Lunie tilted her head, making a confused expression like a human. “We tried all sorts of methods, but we still cannot measure its exact mass.”

“At least we can still drag it. We are slow, but we will tow it back in the end.”

As Lucretia spoke, she turned to look at the bow. Because the chains were only so long, the Radiant Star was now sailing inside the gigantic geometric form projected by the stone sphere. Outside the bow there was only endless radiance. She could not see a normal sea at all.

But she was not worried the ship would lose its way, nor that it would hit reefs or islands.

The stern of the Radiant Star was sailing in the Spirit Realm, and the Spirit Realm was not affected by the stone sphere. Her Ghost sailors on the stern lookout posts and in the enchanted sea chart room could observe the sea conditions and guide the route, making sure the Radiant Star stayed on the correct course.

For ordinary ships this would be unthinkable, but for the Mistress of the Radiant Star, this was something she handled with ease.

“Has Lightwind Harbor received our message?” Lucretia asked with a slight turn of her head. “How did they respond?”

“They have received it,” Lunie answered right away. “A research team made up of a mathematician, a Rune Scholar, and an Occult Specialist is already prepared at the harbor, and people from the Explorer Association are there as well. But I also told them that the Radiant Star is very slow right now, so they will have to wait for a while…”

“It is more than just waiting a while.” Lucretia looked at the golden light covering the sea and could not help pressing her lips together. “Tell them this time I did not find some little trinket—its body is small, but its range of effect is huge.

“Have them choose a proper handover point in the Nearshore Waters, at least two or three nautical miles from the harbor. Otherwise they will have to be ready for the whole harbor district to be covered in endless daytime.”

Lunie lowered her head a bit: “Yes, Mistress. We will pass a lighthouse facility in fifteen minutes. When we do, I will send another telegram to Lightwind Harbor.”

Lucretia made a quiet sound of agreement. Then, as if something came to mind, she suddenly gave a self?mocking little laugh and shook her head.

The doll Lunie looked at her in confusion: “Mistress?”

“It is nothing. I just suddenly thought of some things from long ago,” Lucretia said softly. “Lunie, did you know that I used to scold Father often when he came back from an expedition?”

“Old Master? You scolded him?”

“Yes. I scolded him for always picking up strange things outside,” Lucretia said, as if falling into her memories. She spoke slowly while she thought. “Sometimes he would find a broken stone in the frontier and get so excited he would study it for ten days or half a month, and he would drag my brother and me in to study it with him.”

She turned around and stared in a daze at the chains stretching back from the stern and the stone sphere at their end.

“Now I have picked up a ‘big stone’ and brought it back… I wonder what he would think if he knew.”

Lunie did not know how she should respond to her Mistress. She stayed silent for a moment and then finally said: "…You rarely talk about the Old Master."

"Maybe because so much has been happening lately," Lucretia shook her head. "Let us not talk about this. I am a bit tired. What time is it now?"

"It is already late at night," Lunie nodded. "You really should rest."

"Already late at night?" Lucretia said in surprise, then waved her hand. "Dragging this thing makes it daytime for twenty?four hours straight. My sense of day and night is all messed up… You keep an eye on the ship. I will go rest."

Before she even finished speaking, her figure suddenly broke apart into countless colorful pieces of paper. They fluttered away with the wind, flying toward the captain's cabin.

…

Even after she returned to the Cathedral and evening prayer ended, Vanna still looked troubled and lost in thought—and there was no way such a mood could escape Bishop Valentine's eyes.

When the bishop asked, she did not hide the "meeting in a dream" she had had with that ghost captain on the way back from the harbor.

In the small prayer room connected to the side hall, Valentine quietly listened to Vanna's entire story.

"…I am not surprised that 'he' visited," the old bishop said calmly. "The whole city?state of Pland has already gone through some sort of transformation. Whether we accept it or not, we and the land under our feet have now formed a bond with the Vanished that cannot be cut. I talked about this with your uncle. Do you know what he said?"

“…What did he say?”

“Behind Pland now stands a Master in the Shadows, like the ‘Ten Cities’ described in The Golan Cantos. In those verses there was an Uncrowned King, an unnamed High Regent, a formless but very real ‘owner’ standing in the shadows of those cities. This Master does not declare his authority to the city?state, just like you do not declare to the coins in your pocket that you are their Master—and when you take those coins out, you also do not think about asking their opinion.”

Vanna showed a thoughtful expression: “…‘Ten Cities’ is said to be the most chilling part of The Golan Cantos. It describes how ten city?states were slowly taken over by an invisible ruler and transformed into Shadows. And even when the long poem ends, the writer never describes that ruler even a little bit. He only hints at the Invisible King by describing the atmosphere, customs, and environment in those cities. I have read it, but I was still young at the time. I could not understand why the Lords enjoyed talking so much about the fear in that poem.”

She shook her head lightly.

“But I think at least Captain Duncan is not doing what the ruler in ‘Ten Cities’ did. He is not trying to turn the city?state into some… unspeakable breeding ground. At least for now, he has not shown any malice.”

“That is true. He has not shown any malice. He even went out of his way to warn you,” Bishop Valentine nodded slightly. “The problem with Vision 001 has already caught the attention of the Churches of the Four Gods. But from what I know, the main opinion of the Churches is still to wait and see when Vision 001 will ‘return to normal’. But if the warning Captain Duncan gave is true…”

The old bishop stopped. After a moment, he let out a soft sigh.

“Then our world is facing very big trouble.”

Chapter 266: Spread of Thought

Vanna stood up and walked to the statue of the Goddess in the small prayer room. The statue stood on a high platform, and bright candles burned quietly all around its base.

Bishop Valentine's voice came from behind her: "We should send this warning to the Storm Grand Cathedral, and, if possible, to the other Churches and city-states as well. But that brings us to the source of the warning. If we want it to be convincing, we must give the Churches of the other Three Gods reasons they can accept. Simply saying 'a Saint received a revelation in a dream' is not enough.

"Her Holiness the Pope already knows about your connection with Captain Duncan. She has issued no reprimand, so it looks as if she has tacitly allowed it. But if the other Churches learn the truth… their reactions will be hard to predict, especially on the side of the Church of Death."

"Because of the Viseran Thirteen Isles…" Vanna muttered softly. "The Church of Death is unusually wary of the Vanished."

Valentine sighed: "That's right. The Viseran Thirteen Isles, the sacrifice that was dragged into Subspace by the Vanished. A century ago, they were the largest archipelago city-state under the control of the Church of Death. For the followers of the Death God, those thirteen islands held a place equal to what Pland is today for the Church of the Deep Sea.

"It is troublesome. After a hundred years, it is no longer just about hatred. It is also the natural distrust humans feel toward a runaway state disaster. If

they find out where this warning came from, they might instead start by treating the whole matter as some kind of conspiracy."

Vanna did not speak for a moment. She stayed silent for several seconds before suddenly saying: "The Storm Grand Cathedral will arrive soon. Maybe Her Holiness the Pope will have her own way of handling this."

"I hope so," Valentine muttered, not very confident. "In any case, the Four Gods Church is already paying attention to the situation with Vision 001. It just seems we still are not taking it seriously enough. If the Church of the Deep Sea can take the lead and raise its priority, I think that would at least achieve the effect of this 'warning'."

Vanna slowly nodded. Then she lifted her gaze and fixed her gaze on the statue of the Storm Goddess Gamona. After a long moment, she whispered a soft benediction: "…May you shelter us."

…

On the Vanished, at the stern deck, Duncan had just finished his inspection of the whole ship and was ready to return to his room to rest.

The Vanished needed a full inspection from time to time, especially the lower decks. The compartments flooded by the Boundless Sea needed the captain's intimidation and comfort to stay stable.

During this round of inspection, Duncan had focused again on checking the "door of Subspace" down in the bilge, making sure the door still stayed tightly shut.

That made him feel a bit more at ease.

But alongside this ease, a faint uneasiness still pressed at the bottom of his heart. He still did not understand how he had fallen asleep in his cabin last time and then somehow entered the "other side" of that door.

He had stumbled into Subspace without knowing how, and then spent half a day on another Vanished within Subspace. In the end, he had found a way to return safely, but as long as he could not figure out the mechanism by which he entered Subspace, he could never fully relax.

And the time he entered Subspace had been right after something went wrong with Vision 001.

The Sun had gone wrong, there had been that strange dream, and then he had entered Subspace. The three events followed one after another so closely that it was hard not to suspect some hidden connection behind them.

Duncan stood in front of the captain's cabin, holding the consecrated lantern in one hand. He took a quiet breath in the cold night wind.

Maybe it was exactly this uneasiness that pushed him to send that warning during his earlier Dream Communion with Vanna. He still was not sure how much his bizarre dream reflected the Mortal Realm, but after dealing with supernatural Visions so many times, he at least had one clear lesson: an ordinary person might be allowed to treat a dream as just a dream, but if "Captain Duncan" had a dream… then he must never treat it as just a dream.

Now he only hoped his warning could make the Four Gods Church focus more attention on the problem of Vision 001.

He knew he was not an expert in the supernatural field. Even if he wanted to study Vision 001, he had no way to start. What he could do… was draw the true experts toward this problem.

A warning coming from "Captain Duncan" was without a doubt enough to make many people take it seriously.

Duncan gathered his thoughts and put his hand on the handle of the captain's cabin door. But before he opened it, another matter suddenly came

to mind.

The Abyssal Trench Project that Tyrian had mentioned to him.

Duncan frowned slightly and thought for a moment. Then he directly pushed open the “door of the Lost Ones”.

Swirling thick mist appeared within the frame.

He stepped into it.

After a brief dizziness and a sense of space and time twisting, Zhou Ming opened his eyes and saw his familiar studio apartment. Everything here was still the same as before.

He steadied himself and, as always, first checked the windowsill, the desk, and other spots. After making sure nothing here had changed, he walked to the far end of the room.

On the plain storage shelf, the delicate “models” of the Vanished and Pland still sat quietly in their original places.

Zhou Ming walked over and picked up the “model” that represented Pland. Holding this “collection”, which felt neither too heavy nor too light in his hands, he went to the desk nearby, sat down, and carefully examined the structure of its “base”.

He had never thought about this before. He had to admit that “what lies beneath the city-state” was not only a blind spot in many people’s thinking in this world, it was also a blind spot in his own.

All he saw was a very smooth bottom.

Below the sea level around the city-state of Pland, the model simply ended. The bottom surface was so smooth it looked as if it had been sliced off with a sharp blade.

Zhou Ming fixed his gaze on the base of the model and fell into deep thought.

If it were just a “model”, then of course such a neat, flat underside would be normal. But he knew this “collection” was no ordinary model. It should be the “reflection” or “projection” of Pland in the Mortal Realm, placed in this room. What it showed… should be the complete form of Pland.

No matter what lay under the city-state, whether it was an endlessly long pillar or a thin base like a flat cake, it should still have some kind of structure, not simply end the moment you went below the sea surface.

Was it because he had not burned the city-state thoroughly enough when he used fire on it back then? Or because…

He had “ignored” that part?

Zhou Ming frowned slightly. His fingers tapped the edge of the desk without thinking. Then he pulled himself together, held his hand over the model, and let his mind slowly spread outward.

In the city-state of Pland, inside the antique shop, Duncan had just said goodnight to Nina and Shirley. He silently returned to his room, walked to the window, and quietly looked out at the night scene of the district, where lamps shone everywhere under the still veil of night.

veil of night lay heavy over the city. Almost all the residents had gone home. The streets and alleys were extremely quiet. Only a few moving points of light could be seen deep in the slightly darker lanes. Those were the patrolling Guardians and the glow from the consecrated lanterns in their hands.

Duncan slowly closed his eyes.

The entire city-state of Pland then appeared in his mind from a clearer, more direct vantage point.

Crowded residential districts. Steam factories that never slept. Quiet commercial streets. Damp coastal roads. The gas lamps along the sidewalks. The pipeline systems that crossed whole neighborhoods…

In one part of the city, a Guardian squad walked out from a narrow alley, heading to check the next gas and steam node.

A young squad member holding a consecrated lantern looked at the still, silent street ahead and muttered with a bit of feeling: “Looks like it’s another peaceful night… Honestly, I’m not used to nights this quiet.”

The squad captain glanced at his subordinate: “Don’t relax. Anything can happen during veil of night. Watch the darkest places.”

“Yes, I understand,” the squad member straightened up quickly, but still could not help saying: “But don’t you think it really has been quiet these last two days? I heard that in the latest patrol records there hasn’t even been a single—”

A faint green shimmer suddenly flashed at the edge of his vision, making the squad member stop without thinking.

It seemed the light from a distant gas lamp changed for an instant. It was so brief and subtle it was almost impossible to catch.

“Did you see something flash just now?” The squad member’s hand went to the Runic Steel Sword at his waist as he spoke in a low, serious voice. “The gas lamp seemed to flicker.”

Another squad member spoke at once: “I saw your consecrated lantern flicker too.”

The squad members all turned their eyes toward the captain.

The captain only frowned, clearly thinking about something. After several seconds, this veteran Guardian shook his head: “Keep patrolling. We’ll

report it to the Cathedral when we get back.”

The Guardian squad left that place.

And the same kind of thing was happening all over the city.

Green light passed through flames. Invisible gaze flashed in the dark. Duncan’s thoughts flowed through the entire city-state and then slowly sank deeper.

In that detached yet clear “sense”, Duncan let his consciousness sink bit by bit, exploring the structure of the city-state beneath the surface of the sea.

In the apartment room, Zhou Ming suddenly opened his eyes.

A faint scraping sound reached his ears.

He picked up the “collection” in front of him and stared fixedly at the underside of the Pland city-state.

A rough and complex new structure was “growing” bit by bit on the bottom of the “model”.

Chapter 267: Beneath the Darkness

The bottom of the “model” was growing.

As Zhou Ming–Duncan’s thoughts spread, the structure that represented Pland’s Undercity slowly surfaced in his mind. The parts that appeared in his awareness now turned into corresponding new parts on the “collection” itself.

It was something rough, like a disk of rock, growing at a speed visible to the naked eye. It covered the entire underside of the Pland city-state and then began to extend further, showing more bizarre details—layers of sediment built up over hundreds of years, small spiky growths like fine thorns, and between those layers of sediment, twisted, coiled… strange protrusions.

It felt like the coarse skin of some echinoderm, or the ugly outer layer left on rock after strong acid had corroded it.

At last, the growth stopped.

The “model” that represented the city-state of Pland now had a disk-shaped base at its bottom.

But Zhou Ming frowned.

He could feel that his awareness spreading through Pland had not stopped. It was still extending “downward”.

In the darkness, in the cold, in a Transcendent Perception beyond the ordinary five senses and six faculties, he felt his spirit continue to sink like

mercury seeping into soil. He clearly sensed his “gaze” pass through thick layers of concrete, soil, and rock, and then pass through some extremely dense “shell” that was neither metal nor stone, until it sank into icy seawater. Then it kept going down, and down.

In only the blink of an eye, he felt he had plunged into a pitch-black Deep Sea, passing the 850-meter-thick base and following some invisible but real “path” as it stretched rapidly downward.

And after that, how far did it go? One hundred meters? Two hundred?

Zhou Ming could not be sure. He only knew his perception was still spreading downward. He had already moved beyond the range of the city-state of Pland, and no new structure appeared on the “collection” in his hands, yet his thoughts still flowed along some invisible “medium”.

His first reaction was, of course, tension. He instinctively tried to control this trend of falling toward the Deep Sea. But before he could do anything, that constant “falling” suddenly stopped.

It was as if he had crashed into some invisible “limit” or reached the end of the “medium”. His perception finally settled in deep water at some depth beneath the city-state and stayed there.

Zhou Ming felt his heart pounding. It was the feeling of suddenly falling, only to be yanked to a stop halfway down by a rope. The sharp rise and drop shook him. It took him nearly half a minute to calm down and steady his breathing and heartbeat.

Then he composed himself again, slowly picked up the Pland model in front of him, and looked at the thick “rock disk” spreading outward under its base.

The structure was rough and ugly, yet overall it was fairly regular. Its underside was a jagged broken face. It felt… as if it had been forcibly

snapped off from something else, or as if its growth from top to bottom had been interrupted, leaving behind an ugly break.

The inside of the disk was a murky, chaotic mess, impossible to sense clearly or see through.

But Zhou Ming did not focus on the disk base itself. Instead, he looked at the empty space under the base.

A part of his extended “consciousness” now hung suspended at that spot.

Zhou Ming closed his eyes slightly.

In the next second, the distant perception suddenly grew stronger.

He felt he was in the dark, icy Deep Sea. An immeasurable volume of seawater wrapped around and pressed down on him layer after layer. The pressure was so real that it felt as if even his consciousness was being restrained and bound. He tried to open his “eyes” in that darkness, but he saw only endless nothing.

As time passed, tiny specks of light seemed to appear in that emptiness.

Were they some kind of plankton in the Deep Sea? Some school of glowing fish? Or something else?

Zhou Ming struggled to make it out for a long time before he realized… he was looking at the bottom of Pland.

He was “looking up” at Pland and seeing the underside of that rough disk base. In the extreme darkness, there were a few small glowing structures on that base.

He still could not tell what they were. With only pure mental perception, across such a vast distance and through such thick seawater, the information that could reach him was far too vague.

After that, Zhou Ming slowly adapted and tried to shift his attention in another direction—toward the deeper seabed below.

All he felt was endless emptiness and endless darkness.

There seemed to be nothing in the Deep Sea.

But after a while longer, he suddenly sensed something faint.

Something enormous, utterly still, maybe even as huge as Pland itself, lay sleeping in that boundless darkness.

Zhou Ming could not see it or hear it. The extreme darkness and silence hid every detail of that giant presence. Yet he could be sure that something was there, motionless and dead-quiet, as if it had existed since ancient times.

He did not know how long passed before he finally pulled back.

In the end, he still could not “see” what actually lay in the Deep Sea directly beneath Pland.

But he faintly understood one thing—

That vast structure hiding directly under the city-state was probably the reason Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm had stubbornly pushed the Abyssal Trench Project half a century ago.

There was something under Frostholm. There was something under Pland. Under the other city-states… there was probably something too.

Zhou Ming let out a slow breath, stood up, picked up the Pland city-state model, and walked to the storage shelf at the far end of the room.

The model now had a “base”, but it could still fit into the cubby on the shelf —as if, from the very beginning, both the model and the cubby had left enough space for it.

But before he put the model back, Zhou Ming's eyes fell again on the space under the base, and a trace of doubt rose in his heart.

His awareness could spread through the city-state, but in the Deep Sea, his awareness had clearly gone beyond the physical limits of this model. Its physical base ended after 850 meters, yet his awareness had continued downward for another hundred or two hundred meters. How did those last hundred or two hundred meters extend? What was that invisible medium?

Zhou Ming slowly put the model back onto the shelf.

…

The Sun once again rose into the sky as usual.

In front of the antique shop in Pland's Lower City, on the small open space, Duncan watched Nina ride a bicycle in a cheerful circle, then pedal up and down the street before finally stopping steadily in front of him.

"Uncle! I'm already really good at this!"

Nina planted one foot on the ground, her face bright with excitement and pride.

Duncan smiled a little: "Not bad. You really are getting good at riding—but you stopped with your wheel on my foot."

Nina quickly looked down and, in a panic, rolled the wheel off his shoe: "Ah! I'm sorry!"

"It's fine." Duncan waved his hand with a smile. Then he let out a breath and lifted his head to look at the street in the sunlight.

The city-state was the same as always.

Under the street bathed in sunlight, the deep darkness and massive Shadows below felt like something from another world. They had not affected

people’s daily lives at all.

But ever since he finished his exploration of what lay “beneath” Pland, he could not help thinking of that cold, dark Deep Sea, and of the vast structure he had sensed in it.

It made him drift off in thought again and again.

He even could not help wondering if the queen of Frostholm half a century ago had been the same. Had she also found some way to glimpse the secrets in the Deep Sea… maybe even more than he himself had seen?

“Uncle, you’re spacing out again?”

Nina’s voice came from beside him, cutting off Duncan’s wandering thoughts.

“Are you all right? You’ve been distracted since this morning.”

“I’m fine,” Duncan waved his hand quickly. Then he looked toward the end of the street, as if to change the subject: “But speaking of which, Alice still isn’t back.”

“She just left not long ago,” Nina said casually. “And you don’t have to worry so much, do you? She only went to buy a newspaper. It’s not like she has to cross half the city. She shouldn’t get lost, right?”

“I really can’t relax,” Duncan sighed. “This is her first time going out alone in the real sense—even if it’s only to the newsstand at the corner.”

“I think it’ll be fine,” Nina thought for a moment and answered very firmly. “Before she left, I went through it with her many times. How to tell people what she wants to buy, how to get change, how to say thank you after taking the newspaper… She learned all of it.”

“I hope so,” Duncan sighed. “It’s just that when she first came aboard the ship, even going to the kitchen to get a plate meant getting hit with a frying

pan.”

Nina froze for a second: “I don’t think you can treat those two things as the same…”

While they were talking, Alice’s figure appeared at the edge of their sight.

The doll girl was hugging a newspaper to her chest. Her face shone with a bright smile. She held her neck stiff and ran toward them in little jumps, shouting as she ran: “Mr. Duncan! I got the newspaper!”

Nina laughed: “See? I told you Miss Alice would definitely be fine!”

But when Duncan saw the way Alice ran, he was instantly alarmed. He hurried forward to meet her and shouted: “Don’t run! Slow down!”

As the saying went, you worry about exactly what ends up happening. In the time it took him to say that, he watched Alice trip and go down flat on her front less than five meters away from him, sprawling across the ground.

Yet the very next second, the doll bounced back up as if nothing had happened. She patted off her skirt, picked up the newspaper from the ground, and walked over to Duncan with a beaming smile: “Newspaper!”

Duncan did not take the newspaper right away. Instead, he stared in disbelief at the doll girl whose head was still attached. After a long moment, he finally managed to say: “…You fell that hard. How did your head not come off?”

Alice kept that confident, neck-straight pose, her face glowing with pride: “I found a good way to reinforce it!”

Duncan eyed the doll suspiciously: “A good way?”

Alice said: “I used glue!”

Duncan: “…?!”

He stared at her in shock for two or three seconds, then could not help asking: “Who taught you that?”

“Shirley!”

Chapter 268: Alice with the Firm Head

Looking at Alice, who stood there with her neck stuck straight and a very confident pose, Duncan's mood fell apart all at once. Then he suddenly realized what was wrong with that silly posture. It was not confidence or pride at all. Her neck had simply set in place and could not move anymore.

But the doll herself still did not seem to notice how serious the problem was. She still looked very pleased with herself, grinning as she handed the newspaper to Duncan, clearly overjoyed that she had managed to go shopping alone: "Here you go, the newspaper, and I even remembered the change!"

Duncan finally took the newspaper with a blank face. Two or three seconds passed before he reminded this silly girl: "Alice, try nodding."

"Eh? Why?" Alice froze for a moment, but still obeyed the captain's order at once. Her head only gave a tiny wobble in place. A strange sound came from the area of her neck, and then she could not move it at all.

After two seconds of stunned silence, the doll finally reacted and cried out: "Mr. Duncan! I can't move! Help, help!"

Duncan gave the doll a tired look, then turned and walked toward the antique shop: "Stop yelling out here. We'll look at it inside."

Alice hurried after Duncan in a panic, with Nina, who was also a bit confused and at a loss, following behind her. The three of them went

through the door of the antique shop. Walking last, Nina turned back, carefully closed the shop door, and did not forget to hang up the “Closed for a Break” wooden sign.

Duncan casually tossed the newly bought newspaper onto the counter. He was just about to check Alice’s condition when his eye suddenly caught a headline on the front page.

His attention was drawn back to the paper at once.

There, in the largest bold letters, was printed:

“The Storm Grand Cathedral Will Arrive at Loyal Pland at Noon Tomorrow – May the Glory of the Storm Ruler Bless Us All”

The Storm Grand Cathedral? The Deep Sea Church’s mysterious “headquarters at sea”? Goddess Gamona’s Envoy was coming to this city… was it because of the recent historical corruption incident? Or because of the Vanished? Or both?

Duncan frowned and picked up the newspaper, his gaze scanning the front-page article.

Alice, meanwhile, circled around anxiously. She had finally realized that pouring glue into her neck joint had not been a wise move. When she saw that the captain had no time to care about her, she turned her plea for help toward Nina: “Miss Nina, help me, save save save save save…”

Nina was flustered too. She stepped up and grabbed Alice’s head, trying to shake it from side to side, and found that the glue had already fully hardened: “This… this won’t come off at all! Just one look and you can tell it’s fast-drying glue!”

“Think of something,” Alice sounded like she was about to cry. She held her head with both hands. “Miss Nina, don’t you study repairing machines and stuff? You know how to fix those complicated steam cores. Fix me.”

“I don’t know how to repair dolls!” Nina was also on the verge of panic. In the end she turned her pleading eyes to Duncan. “Uncle, please think of something. Miss Alice’s head is completely glued in place…”

Duncan finally put down the newspaper and turned to look at the two noisy young ladies beside him. His eyes landed on Alice: “How much glue did you pour in, and what kind was it?”

“One bottle, about this big,” Alice said, holding out her hands to show the size. “I found it in your room, a small brown glass bottle.”

“…You poured in the whole thing?!” Duncan’s eye twitched. “That big a bottle, how did you even manage that?”

“I first took my head off and set it upside down, poured the glue inside and shook it a bit, then just stuck it back on,” Alice said, sounding like she might cry. “Shirley said that would be nice and secure…”

Duncan stared at her, dumbfounded. He could feel the beautiful doll’s deep sorrow, but dolls had no tears. All her sadness could only flow silently inside her hollow heart—very poetic words, if you ignored the detail that “the doll was heartbroken because she had glued her own head in place.”

Duncan sighed, tossed the newspaper aside, stepped up to unfasten the lace around Alice’s neck, and checked the hardened superglue around the joint. After a moment of silent inspection, he turned to Nina: “…Where did Shirley go?”

“She… said an hour ago that her head hurt from memorizing vocabulary, so she went out for some fresh air,” Nina said, shrinking her neck. “Do you think she ran away because she feels guilty?”

“I doubt she thought that far at all. These days the only thing she really thinks about is how to skip class,” Duncan sighed and shook his head. “No,

it’s completely dry. It’s been at least half an hour. That’s fast-drying glue. You can’t pull it off by force now.”

“Then what do we do?!” Alice looked at Duncan in panic. “When I comb my hair I have to take my head off. I can’t comb my hair while wearing it.”

“…So after your head got glued in place, that was the only thing you worried about?” Duncan glared at Alice, then wearily waved his hand. “Enough, stop looking so miserable. The glue is strong, but it doesn’t stand up to heat or water. Soak it in hot water. It will soften after a while.”

Alice looked as if she had been saved, and Nina, who had been worrying beside her, reacted at once. She rushed forward to grab Alice’s hand: “I’ll take you to the bathroom. I can boil water really fast now!”

The Sun fragment and the doll with the glued head thumped up the stairs together. Duncan could only sigh helplessly and pick up the newspaper he had set aside.

According to the public statement, the Storm Grand Cathedral was docking in Pland for a routine stop and maintenance. Pope Helena would briefly visit the Pland Grand Cathedral during this time and discuss some Church matters with the Archbishop and the Inquisitor. The newspaper did not mention the historical corruption incident or anything related to the Vanished at all.

But even if the paper did not say it, anyone with eyes could guess that the Deep Sea Pope was coming because of those two major events.

Duncan did not care about belief in the Storm Goddess, but he still wondered what kind of effect this would have on him.

Or rather, could he take this chance… to gather some information?

He still remembered that earlier “thank you,” which had most likely come from the Storm Goddess herself. Even without that, he was curious about

the deities of this world, and he was interested in that great Storm Grand Cathedral that was said to sail the Boundless Sea all year round.

On the other hand, he was also very curious whether the Storm Goddess's highest representative, after coming here, would sense something strange about the city-state of Pland—and whether they would discover his "Subspace Shadows" hidden inside it.

Things were getting interesting.

Duncan put down the newspaper and sat beside the counter, rubbing his chin in thought.

The antique shop was very quiet. He could faintly hear the noise from Nina and Alice in the upstairs bathroom. The clearest sounds were Nina's excited exclamations:

"Wow! These joints are amazing… so pretty!

"Miss Alice, can your wrist really turn three hundred and sixty degrees… it really can?!"

"Miss Alice, there's a keyhole on your back. Huh? You don't know what it's for either?"

"Is it okay if water gets into the keyhole? Oh, then I'm relieved…"

Duncan rubbed his brow, starting to get a headache.

He began to suspect that those two upstairs had already forgotten all about the actual problem.

But soon the sounds upstairs quieted down. Then there was a rush of hurried footsteps thumping toward the stairs, and Nina's voice followed: "Uncle Duncan! It's not working! Please come look, it won't come off at all!"

“…?”

Duncan went upstairs full of confusion. He saw Nina standing in the hallway with a helpless face, then looked past her toward the bathroom at the end of the hall and saw Alice awkwardly peeking out.

Then the doll stepped out, dripping wet, wrapped in a bath towel. Her head was still solidly stuck.

“Captain, it still didn’t work,” Alice said, face long with despair.

“It didn’t loosen at all,” Nina muttered. “We rinsed it with hot water for a long time.”

Duncan looked at Alice, then at Nina, who was nervously twisting the hem of her clothing. After a long moment, he finally sighed.

“Use boiling water.”

“Huh?” Nina jumped in shock. “R-really?! Can Miss Alice handle that…”

“She once deep-fried her own head in oil. She’s not scared of a bit of heat,” Duncan spread his hands. “At this point, hot water isn’t enough. We still have some hope if we cook it in boiling water.”

Nina’s eyes went a little blank. She tried hard to picture the procedure, then said with some hesitation: “Boiling water is easy. I can make it fast. But… we don’t have a pot that big, and we don’t have a tub deep enough to soak her whole body. To get her head fully under water, Miss Alice would at least have to squat in it, right?”

As she spoke she waved her hands around. Even though she always had top grades at school, at this moment Nina still felt her imagination was struggling to keep up with the pace of the Mortal Realm.

But Duncan clearly did not share Nina’s limits in creative thinking. He just glanced at the nearby gothic doll wrapped in a towel and looking pitiful,

then turned to Nina and said: “That’s easy. Just find a big basin. Let her go in headfirst… at worst I’ll hold her.”

Nina pictured it. The scene did appear in her mind, but her tone grew extra hesitant: “I still feel Miss Alice seems kind of pitiful like that…”

“Pitiful my ass!” Duncan finally lost his patience and swore for the first time in ages. “She let an illiterate girl talk her into pouring a whole bottle of glue into her neck joint. Let this teach her a lesson!”

Chapter 269: The Subspace Nest Was Still Cozy Today

“Are you really sure this will work?”

Nina still felt uneasy as she looked at the big basin of water set on the dining table. She glanced at the nervous Alice beside her, then at Duncan’s blank face, and muttered under her breath.

“If this still doesn’t work, we’ll have to use solvent. But that stuff is corrosive. I don’t know if it will damage Alice’s body,” Duncan said crossly as he looked at the gothic doll, who had changed back into her normal clothes but still had a stiff, unmoving neck. “Or she can just keep that posture forever.”

Alice panicked at once and waved her hands: “No, no, let’s try the boiling water first!”

Nina’s gaze went back and forth between Alice and the basin several times. At last she gave a small “oh” and slowly reached her hand into the cool water.

She controlled herself very, very carefully, as if she were trying to pluck a single grain of sand from the desert. She guided that flame that burned deep within her soul, her mental guidance, outward into the water. For a sunlight young lady whose heart burned at six thousand degrees, this kind of precise control was not easy. But in all the free time she had over the past days, she had been practicing this fine control. By now she had improved a lot. In a short time, she succeeded.

The water boiled.

Alice turned to look at Duncan. Duncan looked back at Alice.

Then, without hesitation, he pushed the doll's head down into the basin of boiling water.

"Let's cook it a bit longer," Duncan said helplessly as he held Alice by the shoulders. "But if you feel anything uncomfortable, stop right away."

Alice answered at once: "Glub glub glub… glub."

Duncan thought for a moment, then looked up at Nina: "I'm guessing she doesn't feel anything wrong."

Nina just stared wide-eyed at the scene in front of her. After a long time she could not help muttering: "I still think this looks really creepy…"

Duncan sighed. He did not need to say it—he himself felt the scene was so bizarre it was almost unwatchable. In the dim, narrow second floor of the antique shop, an uncle and a niece were pressing a gothic doll's head into a basin of boiling water. The key part was that this gothic doll even raised her hands and stuck out her thumb from time to time to show she was fine…

Anyone who saw this at first glance would go report it to the constable.

If they took a second look, they would go call a Church guardian.

Right then, footsteps suddenly sounded from the stairs, and Shirley's voice drifted into Duncan and Nina's ears: "I'm back! Mr. Duncan, Mr. Morris came again, I told him to come straight up…"

The next second, Shirley appeared at the door—and her voice cut off.

In the somewhat dim room, Duncan and Nina stood quietly by the basin of boiling water. Nina's hand still rested in the basin, keeping the water at a rolling boil, while Duncan pressed down on Alice's shoulders, holding the

gothic doll’s head under the water. The doll did not move at all. Only the bubbling sound of boiling water filled the room.

Duncan and Nina lifted their heads at the same time and looked at Shirley standing in the doorway.

Then Morris appeared, right behind Shirley.

The scene in the kitchen-slash-dining room reflected in the historian’s eyes.

The old gentleman thought for a moment and understood at once—oh, it was the Subspace Shadows and the Sun fragment stewing Anomaly 099.

Morris nodded. He decided that today the antique shop was as normal as always.

“Holy—!” Shirley finally let out a delayed scream. She almost jumped up, staring in horror at the scene in the room. But then she hurriedly clapped a hand over her mouth, as if trying to shove the swear word back in, and let out a muffled, confused mumble.

“What are you yelling for?” Duncan glared at the jumpy girl at once. “Wasn’t it your idea to have Alice pour glue into her neck?”

Shirley instantly understood what was going on. Her first instinct was to turn and run, but under Duncan’s gaze, she did not dare move at all.

“I… I just said it casually. I didn’t think she would actually do it,” Shirley said, her voice shaking. “What normal person would believe that…”

Duncan heard this and was about to say something, when he suddenly felt Alice’s body sway. He quickly let go, and saw Alice shoot upright from the basin with a splash.

Only her body rose.

Her head was still cooking in the basin.

“Ah, it worked,” Nina said in surprise.

Alice’s body stood there in a daze for a few seconds, then began to feel around for her head with both hands. Her head floated up and down in the basin, making gurgling cries for help: “Help… glub glub… help… glub…”

Nina hurried to fish Alice’s head out and clumsily helped her put it back on. When they heard that familiar soft “pop,” everyone at the scene let out a long breath.

Alice turned her head from side to side. Her neck still felt a bit stiff, but it did move. She immediately grinned and looked at Duncan: “Captain! I can move again!”

“Take her to dry her hair. Her collar’s wet too, help her dry it,” Duncan said with a sigh as he looked up at Nina. Then he glanced at Shirley, who looked like she was about to die of panic, wanting to run but too scared to move, and said sharply, “Copy the alphabet twenty times later, and copy each new word twenty times.”

He ignored Shirley’s sudden “world-ending” expression, and turned to Morris: “What happened? Is it something new about that symbol?”

Morris might not have fully recovered from the eerie, chaotic, and absurd scene just now. He stared blankly for a second before reacting and speaking: “Ah, no, it’s not about the symbol. I suddenly got some news from a friend at City Hall today, and I thought… you might be interested.”

“News from City Hall?” Duncan frowned. “Tell me in detail.”

A few minutes later, Morris finished explaining what he had learned early that morning.

“Visions–Pland…” Duncan sat at the table, his expression slightly serious as he repeated the term. Then he looked at Morris. “When will this be announced to the public?”

“They haven’t decided yet, but likely in the next few days,” Morris said with a nod. “From a normal point of view, Pland is still in the aftermath of the recent disaster. Most citizens’ ability to accept bad news is still high. If they announce the city-state’s transformation into a Vision now as one of the conclusions of the disaster’s aftermath, it might not cause too much chaos. But if they wait until the city is completely calm and everyone has been living peacefully for a long time, then announce it, it could cause a new wave of panic.”

Duncan nodded lightly and did not answer. In his mind, he could not help recalling the news he had just read in the paper.

The Storm Grand Cathedral was coming to Pland.

Changes to the register of Anomalies and Visions were issued outward from the major Churches, so the Storm Grand Cathedral must be the first to know about the situation.

“A city-state turned into a Vision and still running as usual. That’s already very strange. But what’s even stranger is that this new Vision has no number,” Morris added. “Do you… have any thoughts on that?”

Of course Duncan had noticed the problem of this unnumbered Vision. But what opinion could he have? His knowledge of occult studies was not even as good as Dog’s…

He definitely could not say that out loud. So he only paused for a moment, then shook his head calmly: “I have no opinion. The ‘codes’ of the Anomalies and Visions that the Churches publish mean nothing to me and make no sense to me.”

“This…”

Morris opened his mouth, then thought of the green flames that once burned across the entire city-state, of the collapsing Black Sun, and of Anomaly

099, who had just been held under boiling water but behaved so obediently.

All of these seemed the same to Captain Duncan. They were just… "everyday problems" that needed a bit of handling.

No one needed to care what each speck of dust they swept up every day was called.

"All right, then it really doesn't mean much to you," the old scholar said, looking at Duncan with a touch of awe. Then he hesitated again and slowly chose his words. "Also, even though there shouldn't be any doubt, I still want to confirm. It was you who transformed Pland into a Vision… right?"

Duncan tilted his head a little: "Do you have any doubts about that?"

"No, I don't doubt it. I'm just curious what plans you have for this city-state," Morris said, still choosing his words carefully, trying to make himself as clear as possible. "You transformed it into a Vision because you want to…"

"I have no wish to control this city-state's fate, and I don't intend to interfere with anyone's future," Duncan said, cutting him off with a small shake of his head. "If I have to say anything…"

He paused, turned, and looked out the window, at the peaceful scene on the street.

"I rather like this place. So I hope it can stay safe in the future."

…

Inside the Storm Grand Cathedral, Vanna suddenly stopped in the middle of a conversation with Heidi and turned her head with a puzzled look.

"What is it?" Heidi asked, curious as she looked at her friend.

“I seem to have heard a bell ring just now, and someone whispering to me,” Vanna said with a frown. “I must have heard wrong.”

“You definitely heard wrong. I didn’t hear anything,” Heidi waved her hand. “You’ve been too stressed lately. Do you need me to give you a…”

“No!” Vanna quickly cut her off. “I feel like my mental state is just fine. And if I really run into a problem, I can handle it myself. You know that priests are half psychiatrists.”

“Fine, fine, if you don’t need it, you don’t need it. No need to be so tense,” Heidi muttered helplessly. “Right, where was I just now?”

Vanna thought for a second and reminded her: “You said your father went to the antique shop and bought a shell back, and now you’re very worried about his mental state…”

Chapter 270: A Letter from Afar

Earlier, Father went to the antique shop and stayed there for a long time. When he came back, he was holding an artillery shell. Then he solemnly put that thing in the best spot on the antique shelf and, every few days, he would go and carefully polish it.

Every time she thought about this, Heidi worried a lot about the Old Gentleman's mental health at home.

"I'm serious, you have no idea how strange it looks," the young psychiatrist could not help sighing again. "He treats it like a treasure and says it's a very, very special antique. Every day, before he even washes his face, he has to wipe the shell first. And my Mother just refuses to care about it. If I say a couple of things from the side, she just says: 'Your Father only has this one little collecting hobby, don't bother him.'"

Vanna really did not know how to comment on this. She knew nothing about antiques. The deepest impression she had of antiques in her whole life was when, as a child, she practiced a jumping chop with a toy sword and smashed Uncle's vase. She still remembered the beating from that day. So now, after holding it in for a long time, she only managed to say in a dry voice: "…Mr. Morris is a well?respected history scholar and collector. I think there must be something special in his taste for collecting."

"That still doesn't explain hugging an artillery shell like a treasure – even if the shell is real," Heidi sighed. "That shell is definitely real. At least it's solid. It's heavy, really heavy."

Vanna did not speak for a moment. She seemed to be thinking. After a while she suddenly said: “Let’s talk about that amulet instead. Did Mr. Morris get you another amulet just like the old one?”

“Yes, that’s the one,” Heidi nodded. As she spoke, she reached into the front of her clothes and pulled out the ‘crystal’ pendant hanging at her chest. “You’ve seen it. I used to have one exactly the same, but it was destroyed in the last ‘disaster’. The friar who registered me back then analyzed it and said it might have been an item that accidentally picked up supernatural power but usually hid its own special nature…”

Vanna looked at the ‘crystal’ pendant that Heidi had taken out. Her expression seemed thoughtful.

“Do you feel something is wrong?” Heidi could not help asking.

“…After the disaster, the Cathedral was short on people, but we still sent someone to investigate that antique shop,” Vanna said slowly. Her eyes never left the pendant. “The result was that everything was normal. From the shop’s supply channels to the Shopkeeper’s own identity and background, there were no problems at all. Everything was written clearly in the city archives. The thing with the pendant really did seem like a coincidence.

“But I still can’t help caring about it… Heidi, do you remember? I once went to that antique shop with you.”

“Of course I remember,” Heidi nodded. “To be honest, I really have some fate with that shop. The Shopkeeper saved my life at the City Museum. The Shopkeeper’s Niece is also one of my Father’s students. And my previous pendant just happened to come from that shop…

“But you said it yourself. The Church investigated in secret and found nothing wrong.”

Vanna did not answer. After thinking for a moment, she held out her hand: “Can you let me take a look?”

Heidi did not think much of it. She simply took off the pendant and handed it over: “Sure, here.”

Vanna took the crystal pendant, which still held a trace of body heat, and lifted it up to study it carefully in the sunlight. After a long time, she spoke as if talking to herself: “There’s no supernatural aura at all.”

“Right, it’s just an ordinary charm amulet. It’s not even real crystal, it’s glass,” Heidi said. Then she looked a little more seriously at the friend in front of her. “Vanna, you’re a bit too tense. I know it’s your occupational habit as an Inquisitor, but I really think… that Shopkeeper is a very good person. You shouldn’t suspect him.”

“I’m paying attention, not suspecting,” Vanna said, returning the pendant to her friend. “I just always feel that something is off about that antique shop. But I’m not looking at it the way an Inquisitor looks at a Heretic.

“Still, you have a point. Maybe my nerves are a bit too tight.”

Heidi put the pendant back on. Then she glanced at the mechanical clock hanging to the side: “Ah, it’s already this late?!”

“You’re leaving?”

“I have to go,” Heidi said as she stood up and picked up the little case she had put next to her earlier. “I have an appointment this afternoon – that captain who stayed here at the Cathedral in Quarantine Observation for quite a few days.”

Vanna frowned and thought for a moment, then quickly found the matching memory: “The captain of the White Oak? I remember his name is Lawrence… did he run into trouble?”

“He’s a captain who runs back and forth on the Boundless Sea, and he’s at that age,” Heidi said. “It’s completely normal for someone like that to need a psychiatrist’s help.”

She seemed to think of something and her expression grew a bit complicated. But she quickly shook her head. “Compared to most captains his age, Mr. Lawrence is actually not in bad shape. I can’t say more. That’s the patient’s privacy.”

“All right. I wish your work goes well.”

Morris did two things as soon as he came home.

The first was to hug and kiss his Wife.

The second was to carefully wipe the artillery shell on the antique shelf.

He still felt a bit strange in his heart when he brought this thing back, but he knew this strange ‘collection’ had a special meaning.

It stood for his connection with the Vanished. It also stood for Captain Duncan’s “goodwill” toward his Retainers.

That unbelievable ghost captain always chose all kinds of strange ways to show his goodwill. This included, but was not limited to, soup boiled with Deep Sea Spawn, an artillery shell stamped with a steel mark from a century ago, and tutoring the less educated Retainers in reading and writing. At first, Morris felt this was a bit odd, but now he had already adjusted his mindset perfectly.

Whatever Captain Duncan said was right. Whatever Captain Duncan did was normal.

With this mindset, Morris felt he had completely adapted to the atmosphere of the new team.

Footsteps sounded behind him.

Morris did not turn around. He already knew it was his Wife.

“You’re about to polish it so much it could reflect a person,” the dignified old lady said with a smile as she looked at her Husband. “Didn’t you say before that antiques should not be polished too often?”

“But this isn’t an ordinary ‘antique’, Mary,” Morris turned his head and smiled at his Wife. “It is part of the sacred miracles.”

The old lady looked up and studied the two special pieces on the antique shelf – a dagger and an artillery shell. After a moment, she suddenly asked: “Will you tell our Daughter the truth later? About these ‘sacred miracles’, and about… your new ‘identity’.”

Morris stopped what he was doing.

There were some sacred miracles that could be kept from others, but not from the one who had gone through the miracle itself.

As the product of a once?incomplete Subspace Prayer, his Wife had lain in bed as an Ashen Humanoid for eleven years. She knew that very well. Now she lived again because of the influence of the Vanished. Of course she would question her own survival.

There was no way around it.

So, after getting the captain’s permission, Morris told his Wife about the Vanished. But he did not tell Heidi.

“…There’s no need yet,” Morris said. “Heidi doesn’t have to come into contact with this for now. And whether we tell her or not… also depends on what the captain wants.”

Just then, the doorbell suddenly rang and cut off the talk between Morris and his Wife.

The old scholar was about to open the door, but his Wife stopped him with a smile: “I’ll go – I haven’t moved around for many years. I need to exercise more now.”

She turned and went to the front hall. Short voices came from the door. After a while, she came back to Morris.

“It’s the Postman,” his Wife handed over a letter. “For you.”

“A letter for me?” Morris was a bit surprised. The first thing he noticed was the high?value stamps on the envelope and a few special postmarks. He frowned. “I did write to a few distant friends, but they shouldn’t be replying this quickly… hm?”

His hands suddenly stopped. His eyes fell on the first postmark that showed where the letter had been sent from. His face grew a bit strange.

“Where is it from?” his Wife asked curiously.

Morris was silent for two seconds, then said in a low voice: “…Frostholm.”

“Frostholm? That’s very far away,” his Wife said. She thought for a moment and then added, a bit unsure: “I remember you have a friend in Frostholm, called Brown or Bren?”

“Brown Scott,” Morris said slowly. His tone, for some reason, became especially low and serious, and the motion of the letter opener in his hand grew especially slow. “Just like me, he is a scholar of history and is deeply devoted to the field of occult studies.”

“Oh, right, Brown Scott. I remember he was quite thin and gave people a very strict feeling,” his Wife said with sudden understanding. “You still keep in touch with him? I remember he moved to Frostholm many years ago, but before he moved, you two really…”

“He is already dead,” Morris suddenly said. “He died six years ago in a shipwreck.”

As soon as he spoke, the room fell silent.

Chapter 271: From Frostholm

Morris used the letter opener to carefully open the letter that had come from far away.

On the envelope, postmark after postmark, along with the mark that showed it had undergone purification, quietly told him of an extremely long journey.

With the soft sound of paper being unfolded, line after line of neat, beautiful handwriting appeared in front of Morris. It was indeed the handwriting he knew well from his old friend:

“To my friend and partner in scholarship:

“It seems that many years have passed since our last contact. This distance between us really should not have happened. I feel that in these years I have lived in a daze yet stayed busy, as if I have always been doing things that have no meaning. Only recently did I suddenly realize how much time I have wasted…

“…Many strange things have happened lately. Forgive me, but I find it hard to describe in words the changes in my life… Frostholm is an incredible place. It does not only have a cold and long winter. There are also many things here that are worth our careful study…

“Do you still remember the last time we met and talked about those ancient legends from the frozen seas in the far north? Those topics have entered my mind again recently. I suddenly feel that I have grasped some key point, something that can help us sort out many of the questions we could not

solve back then, such as whether there were once city?states upon the frozen sea, and the origin of many mysterious local customs here in Frostholm…

“Frostholm truly is an incredible place, my friend. My mind has become clearer and clearer on this point. There are many mysterious past events in this cold sea that are worth our exploration. I plan to visit some well? respected people in the fields of history and folklore. I also have plans to visit Cold Harbor in the near future. But most important of all, I want to invite you to come here as a guest…

“We have not seen each other for many years, Morris. You said you do not like the cold air of the north, but I think you will like the warm fireplace in my home and the fine wine I have collected. Think about it carefully. We can once again sit beside the glowing fire and talk about those fascinating secrets. Believe me, Frostholm really is an incredible place…

“Won’t you come and see it for yourself? Come to this incredible city?state of Frostholm…

“Your most trusted friend and partner in scholarship,
“Brown Scott, 1900-12-2, written at 42 Hearth Street.”

Morris’s gaze quietly moved over the last line. For a long time, he said nothing.

Only after several minutes did he mutter as if to himself: “It is his handwriting. And those things he mentions really are what we discussed.”

“Today is December 17. This letter was sent half a month ago,” his Wife said beside him, her voice filled with a faint uneasiness. “Considering the distance between Frostholm and Pland, that is a normal amount of time.”

“Yes, the time is normal. The postmarks are normal. What is not normal is that the man who wrote it died years ago,” Morris said slowly. “I still

remember the day I received the obituary – that was also a letter from Frostholm. It was written by his favorite Student. She wrote that her Teacher fell overboard by accident while sailing to Cold Harbor. They never even recovered the body."

"…I don't remember this. It happened during the years when I was muddled," his Wife came closer and held Morris's hand. "We should report this to the Church. The content and wording of this letter look normal, but if you dig into it, it is very unsettling."

Morris squeezed his Wife's hand back and let out a slow breath: "Of course, we should report it to the Church… but not only to the Church."

On the Vanished, in the captain's cabin, Duncan braced both hands on the chart table and stared intently at the mist?shrouded enchanted sea chart and the route slowly spreading across it.

The phantom mark that stood for the Vanished moved slowly at the center of the enchanted sea chart. The dense fog around the Vanished faded little by little as the ship sailed forward. At one end of the route, he could see the city?state of Pland, already left behind for the moment. Outside the route, in the thinner mist, he could faintly see another point of light, glowing very slightly.

Duncan fixed his gaze on that point.

That was the Sea Mist.

After that last battle of mutual fire coverage during "Plague dusk", the mark of the Sea Mist had appeared on this enchanted sea chart.

In Duncan's own senses, he could also roughly feel the current heading of the Sea Mist and even its general condition.

This sense was very vague, but it did not seem to fade as the distance between the Vanished and the Sea Mist grew.

Clearly, just like the “Marked” who had once been stained by the flames of spirit form, the Sea Mist, which had taken an artillery shell from the Vanished full in the face, had also formed a connection with him.

But it was only a “connection”, not complete control like he had over the Vanished. So, on the enchanted sea chart, the Sea Mist only showed up as a single point of light and could not clear away the fog covering its sea lanes.

“Are you choosing our next course?” Goathead’s voice suddenly came from the edge of the chart table. “I have about one hundred and forty very useful suggestions. I can…”

“No, you cannot,” Duncan cut him off with skill before he could start rambling. “I don’t need any suggestions. I have my own plan.”

Goathead shook his head, as if he still wanted to say more. But before he could speak, footsteps sounded outside the door, and the door of the captain’s cabin was pulled open from the outside. Alice walked in.

Then the doll girl froze for a second. Before Duncan could speak, she hurriedly turned around, closed the door, and knocked on it.

“…There is no need to knock after you come in. Knocking should be done before you open the door,” Duncan looked at her with a blank face. “Is everything on ‘that side’ cleaned up?”

“Mm?mm,” Alice nodded at once. “The shelves on the first floor are tidied up, the counter and the stairs are all wiped, and the kitchen is cleaned too!”

“Mm,” Duncan answered casually. “Where is Ai?”

“She went to the kitchen after dropping me off,” Alice said. “She kept shouting something about Crazy Thursday while she flew away…”

“She really knows how to enjoy herself,” Duncan said with a small laugh and shook his head. Then he suddenly noticed that Alice’s neck still moved

a bit stiffly when she nodded. He frowned without thinking. “Why does your neck move so strangely… did you not clean all the glue out of the joint?”

When Alice heard this, she shook her head left and right. Her neck clearly caught and lagged with every movement.

“I guess… it is a bit like that,” the doll girl said, looking a little embarrassed. “It feels kind of… stuck.”

Duncan’s eyelid twitched. He looked helplessly at the doll, while she held her head with both hands. After a long moment, she let out her trademark laugh: “Hehe…”

“Don’t ‘hehe’,” Duncan sighed. “Come here. I’ll clean it for you. If you don’t clear the leftover glue, it will damage the joint even more. And it bothers me to see your head jerk like that every time you nod.”

“Oh.”

Alice walked over at once, very obedient. When she came to Duncan’s side, she reached up, grabbed her own head, twisted it left and right twice, and then “pop” – pulled it off.

The headless doll held her own head in both hands: “C?c?captain, here… here… for you.”

A faint sense of strangeness rose in Duncan’s heart, but he still reached out and took Alice’s head. Then he pulled a scraper, a brush, and a soft cloth from the small drawer under the chart table. With a sigh, he began to examine the joint of this foolish girl.

He could not help feeling a bit emotional.

He had already become able to face such bizarre scenes so calmly and even take part in them as if it were the most natural thing in the world.

Human adaptability really was a strange thing.

He picked up the scraper and gently scraped away the pieces of glue left in the joint, which were no longer very firm. Duncan lifted his eyelids and let his gaze sweep over Alice's face.

Her silver hair spread out over the chart table. The doll blinked and met his eyes.

She really was beautiful – a face so delicate and perfect that, no matter how strange the situation was, it could make people ignore the weirdness for a moment and silently praise that beauty instead.

It was a pity that, in everyday life, this girl's behavior was ridiculous past a certain limit. So while Duncan admired her pretty looks, he mostly felt regret in his heart that she had a mouth at all…

"Do you feel uncomfortable anywhere?"

"N?no, no, no, just a little, little bit itchy, but it is… it is very light," Alice stammered.

Then she went quiet. Even Goathead beside them fell strangely silent. In the room, only the faint scraping of the tool and the soft sound of waves outside the window remained.

After some unknown time, Alice suddenly opened her mouth again.

She stammered, her tone holding a bit of hesitation and a rare hint of sadness: "C?c?captain, am I… am I very, very stupid?"

Duncan's hand suddenly stopped.

He was surprised that this doll could even have this kind of self?awareness and thought.

But then he simply shook his head with a blank face: “Why are you suddenly thinking about that?”

“I… I?I can never learn the things you?you teach me, and I al?always mess things up, and I… I?I just waste your… your time.”

Duncan stayed silent for a moment, then lifted the scraper again.

“I don’t think you are wasting my time,” he said calmly. “Also, you are indeed a bit stupid.”

“S?s?so that’s… that’s how it is.”

“But that’s nothing,” Duncan went on. “Everyone has things they are good at and things they are not good at. We are only ‘stupid’ in the parts we are not good at. Maybe you just have a few more parts you are not good at.” He glanced at Alice’s eyes. “Do you care about this a lot?”

“I… I?I don’t know. I didn’t… didn’t think about it before, but I am af?af? afraid this will slow… slow your work…”

“Then put away these useless worries,” Duncan shook his head. “You just need to go on living happily. If you run into something you can’t learn, then study it a few more times.”

“W?w?will you t?t?teach me a f?few more times then?”

“…If I have the time.”

Alice blinked. She seemed to think for a moment, then slowly smiled.

“Hehe…”

Hearing that familiar laugh, Duncan could not help smiling as well. He picked up the brush and the soft cloth and began to clean away the dry flakes of glue he had scraped off.

Just then, a distant yet clear voice suddenly sounded in his mind.

It was the voice of Morris.

Chapter 272: Turning North

Duncan paused in his work of cleaning the leftover glue from Alice, as if he were listening carefully to some distant sound. After a moment, he lowered his head again and used a soft cloth to wipe away the bits of debris on the table.

Alice blinked, looking at the captain with curiosity: “C?captain, w?what just h?happened?”

“Morris received a letter from a friend far away, and he is not very sure about what that letter says,” Duncan smiled as he stood up. While he went on cleaning the thin layer of dried glue from the joint in Alice’s neck, he said casually: “He wants me to help him check on the situation.”

“A friend f?far away?” Alice’s head, resting on the chart table, gave out a stuttering voice: “Is h?he in d?danger? Are we g?going to r?rescue him?”

Not much glue was left on the neck joint, and it was much easier to clean than the glue stuck in the hollow of the head joint. Duncan quickly dealt with the bit of dried glue and carefully finished the last strokes of wiping. Then he bent down and lifted Alice’s head, handling her as if she were a work of art, and gently set her back in place.

“We may be going to save someone,” he said softly as he turned the doll’s head left and right, “but we may also be going to help him rest in peace. Either way, we have to sail very far.”

As the doll’s head settled into place, the dull look in Alice’s eyes suddenly became lively. She gave her head a small shake, like a puppet that had just

been given a soul, and her speech became smooth again: “Ah, then where are we going?”

Duncan put away the cleaning tools and looked toward the misty enchanted sea chart.

On the enchanted sea chart, the small light that stood for the Sea Mist was moving slowly. It had already sailed some distance away from Pland.

“North,” he said in a low voice, his gaze falling on Goathead. “Raise the jib and the topsail. Turn north—follow the Sea Mist.”

“Aye, Captain!”

……

Heidi set a small brown medicine bottle on the coffee table. About three? fifths of the clear potion inside was still left. In the slowly sinking evening sunlight, the liquid reflected a soft golden glow. In those ripples of gold, tiny bubbles seemed to rise out of it again and again, flickering near the surface without rest.

“This is the last dose. It is a little stronger than the medicines you used before. You can take it when you go to sea, three drops each time—though I suggest you start taking it now as well,” Miss Psychiatrist raised her head and looked at the gray?haired old captain in front of her. “As a captain who has spent half his life on the Boundless Sea, you should take better care of your health.”

“Thank you for the advice, Miss Heidi. I know my own condition,” Lawrence was neither impatient nor very warm. He picked up the bottle in curiosity and held it up in the sunlight to look at the bubbling liquid through the glass. “…It is a very pretty potion. Is it bitter?”

“A little, but mostly it tastes of herbs. I also added some honey to cover the bitterness,” Heidi said. “It will not be hard to swallow.”

As she spoke, she lifted her head and glanced at the sky outside the window.

The Sun was slowly sinking, and its slightly orange?red light shone through the glass window into the living room.

This was the home of Lawrence, captain of the White Oak. As an old and seasoned captain, Lawrence had filled his living room with many items that proved his years at sea—coral specimens taken from shallow coastal waters, models of wheels and ships, totems from distant city?states, and a large rack against the wall. It was packed with awards and souvenirs given by the Explorer Association, the city?state authority, and the four great Churches.

Now all these things that stood for glory and memories were submerged in the slanting sunlight, coated with a layer of golden glow that slowly faded.

It was time to leave. After the Sun went down, it was no longer a good time to go on with mental counseling.

“I should go,” Heidi let out a small breath and rose from the sofa. Her gaze fell on the bottle in Lawrence’s hand. “Please do not forget to take it. It can help you resist the mental strain brought by the Boundless Sea.”

“Thank you. You have already helped me a lot,” the gray?haired Lawrence also stood up, a sincere smile on his face. “I will walk you out.”

Heidi was escorted to the door by the old captain, but before she left, she could not help looking at Lawrence a few more times and saying: “I have one last piece of advice. Your condition is still fairly good compared to other captains your age, but you really have reached retirement age. You should think about handing the White Oak over to a reliable successor.”

After saying what she wanted to say, she did not wait for his answer. She simply gave a small polite bow and said goodbye before leaving.

The figure of Miss Psychiatrist walked toward the car parked at the corner of the street, and Lawrence let out a light sigh and turned back into the living room.

His wife was leaning with her arms folded against the nearby doorframe, looking this way with some displeasure.

She was a tall woman. Though now she was getting old, one could still see a hint of the grace she had in her youth. She stood there as if she were once again standing on the deck of a ship…still that famous female explorer on the Boundless Sea.

But the mood of this former explorer was clearly not very good.

“Day after day, it is either Church inspections or a psychiatrist coming to the door. Just what kind of trouble did you cause out there!” She glared at him and raised her voice. “And what is with that medicine bottle? You never said your mind had gotten so bad you needed drugs just to keep going.”

“It was not as if I wanted to run into that ghost ship,” Lawrence glanced at the bottle in his hand and shook his head helplessly. “But it is fine now. The whole city?state went through the Vanished incident, so no one cares about the White Oak anymore. As for this medicine…it is nothing. After spending so long at sea, it is normal to have the odd hallucination now and then.”

His wife did not answer. She only stared at him for a long time. After several minutes she sighed: “Still not retiring?”

“I want to search a bit more…” Lawrence said, not very sure of himself. “After all…back then there was never any clear news of their deaths…”

“You are going to die out there sooner or later!” His wife raised her voice again and pointed at Lawrence’s nose. “What was that? It was a great storm on the Boundless Sea! A storm like that passes, a ship goes off its route, and

an entire crew disappears without contact—that means they are dead! Do you understand?

“Look at yourself. How many years have you been searching? You are long past the age of retirement. The captains who started with you and had some sense have already retired. Now they can at least enjoy the savings they built up over half a life. And those foolish ones who held on like you—what ends did they meet? Drooling in bed? Lying in the graveyard? Locked up in an asylum?

“I am telling you to take this medicine right now. Then tomorrow go do the handover. Give the White Oak to one of those trusted men you trained from when he was young. Come home and live out the rest of your days on your pension. Do not damn well wait until the day you die in some storm too. I cannot carry that worry for you…”

Lawrence listened to his wife’s scolding as her voice grew louder and louder. He only gave a mild smile and did not argue. At last he set the small brown bottle back on the coffee table and said: “Let me search one last time.”

His wife finally fell silent. She stared at the bottle on the table. After who knew how long, she let out a breath that still held some anger and muttered as if giving in: “Where will you search this time?”

“North,” Lawrence said calmly. “The first place. The waters where the Black Oak met the storm. I have just taken an escort job to Frostholm…”

His wife did not say anything. She only waved her hand in silence.

……

Morning sunlight spread over the streets, and Pland was slowly waking from a night’s sleep.

Vanna bent to step out of the car and narrowed her eyes a little in the sunlight. At the end of her gaze she saw the familiar sign of the antique shop she had visited once before.

The shop was already open. A thin, small girl with black hair and a black dress was sprinkling water at the door. Another girl about the same age was hanging the open sign on the front door.

If she remembered right, one girl was named Shirley and the other Nina—the latter was the shopkeeper's niece.

Vanna rubbed her forehead and tried to recall her last visit to the antique shop. For some reason, some of the details now felt strangely blurry.

That only made her more sure she needed to come and take a look today.

A subordinate's voice came from inside the car: "How long will you be away?"

"Within an hour," Vanna answered. "Just wait here for me."

"All right." The young guardian in charge of driving nodded in the car, but still reminded her with some worry: "Please watch the time. Today is the day the Storm Cathedral arrives in Pland. You must attend the welcoming ritual in person. Bishop Valentine asked me to remind you. Also, this stop was not on our schedule…"

"All right, all right. You have already said that several times," Vanna waved her hand, looking a bit helpless. "I know everyone is nervous about the Storm Cathedral docking this time. I will watch the time."

"…All right, then I will wait here for you."

Chapter 273: charm amulet?

A tall figure suddenly blocked the sunlight.

Shirley had just finished sprinkling water on the ground in front of the shop and was carrying the empty basin back when she froze. She looked up and saw, backlit by the light, an inquisitor standing quietly in front of her.

“…Holy crap!!” she blurted out before she could stop herself. Then she suddenly caught herself, coughed twice in a hurry, and tried to put her words together with a very tense face: “Uh, well, you…you…”

Vanna frowned slightly. For some reason, she felt that this small, thin girl was much too nervous every time she saw her. It had been like this the last time she and Heidi came to this antique shop, and it was still the same now.

But she did not think much of it. For many reasons, she was already quite used to this “nervous reaction” when people saw her.

“I remember your name is Shirley,” Vanna said with a smile, trying to put the short girl at ease. “Do not be so nervous. I am only here to look around.”

Shirley quickly stood up straight and nodded stiffly: “Uh…ah! Right, welcome…”

Vanna shook her head in helplessness, stepped past the still?tense Shirley, and gave a small nod to greet Nina, who was watching curiously. Then she headed straight for the antique shop.

When she pushed open the door, the clear sound of a bell rang out, breaking the quiet on the antique shop's first floor. Vanna stepped inside and turned her gaze to the figure behind the counter.

In the next second, she frowned in slight surprise.

In the morning sunlight, a blond woman Vanna had never seen before was sitting behind the counter. She was a very…beautiful lady, with an elegant and mysterious air that felt as if it did not belong to this place, or even to this age. Her profile seemed to glow with a warm light in the sun.

When she heard the sound at the door, the blond woman behind the counter lifted her head and gave Vanna, who was walking in, a curious look. She showed a faint smile, and her voice was soft and a little husky: "Welcome. Take your time and look around?"

Vanna went blank for a moment. For some reason, she felt that this new face in the antique shop should not be here. But in the next moment, she felt that the woman's mysterious and elegant air oddly matched the atmosphere the antique shop gave off…

This place was full of all kinds of old and mysterious?looking things. It seemed right that a lady with a mysterious and elegant air should be sitting behind the counter.

But everything in this antique shop was a replica.

Vanna fixed her gaze on the blond woman behind the counter.

Ah, yes. replicas.

"Excuse me…" Alice looked at Vanna in some confusion. After coming in, Vanna had just stood there staring off into space, and this seemed to go beyond the captain's usual "standard process for dealing with guests." Alice suddenly did not know what to do. "Are you here to buy something?"

Vanna gave a little start and snapped back to herself.

A hazy numbness and dizziness filled her head, making her thoughts break apart. She vaguely remembered that she had just seen something or thought of something, but the sudden confusion wiped away everything she had seen and known in that instant.

In the next second, the sound of gentle waves rose again in her mind. In that sound, even the numbness and dizziness from just now faded from her memory.

She felt as if she had only just walked into the shop, and the young woman behind the counter was talking with her.

“Ah, is Mr. Duncan not here?” Vanna looked around the first floor in curiosity and did not see the antique shopkeeper. “I know him.”

“Mr. Duncan? He went upstairs to put something away. He will be down soon,” Alice did not care much about Vanna’s daze just now. As long as the talk could go on, she felt everything was fine. “Do you want to buy something? Did you reserve something? I can help you look for it—though I may not be able to find it…”

What a blunt way to put it.

Vanna felt strange. Her instincts told her that there was something off about the pretty young woman in front of her, but every time she tried to focus on that thought, it slipped away at once. Even her speech became slower than usual: “I…am just looking. I will wait for a bit. May I ask…are you new? I did not see you the last time I was here.”

“Ah, I am new. My name is Alice,” Alice said at once with a smile. She liked introducing her name to others. “Mr. Duncan asked me to help mind the shop.”

Vanna seemed to sense something faintly wrong. It hid in Alice's reserved yet slightly stiff movements, in that perfect yet a bit too perfect smile, and even in the way she spoke with no breath flowing through her words.

The inquisitor frowned, but she still did not truly catch anything strange.

It was only a new shop assistant. There was nothing odd about that.

Just then, footsteps sounded from the nearby stairs, cutting off the talk between Vanna and Alice.

Duncan's figure appeared on the staircase.

Just now he had already sensed Vanna's arrival. To be sure of this inquisitor's purpose, he had stayed on the second floor for a few extra minutes. Only when he saw that she did not seem to have any special reason for coming did he walk down.

"Looks like we have a special guest," Duncan said to the doll behind the counter. "I will take care of this one. We know each other—Alice, go make some tea."

"All right, Mr. Duncan!"

Alice stood up happily. After answering, she walked toward the small stove on the other side of the stairs. Duncan came over to stand in front of Vanna and greeted this inquisitor he had already met many times with a smile: "Long time no see, Miss Inquisitor."

"Just call me by my name," Vanna rubbed her forehead. "Sorry for coming without warning. I actually have some questions I want to confirm."

"Questions?" Duncan raised his eyebrows. "What kind of questions?"

Vanna steadied herself and thought about how to begin.

Some vague clues pointed toward this plain little shop. Some instinct had led her here. The experience and senses of an inquisitor seemed to stir inside her. Yet the Church had already investigated this place through official channels and had found no anomaly at all. The only reason she really had to support this visit seemed to be her friend's amulet.

"As far as I know, Heidi once had an amulet that came from here," Vanna said slowly. "Before that Mortal Realm corruption disaster, she always wore it."

"Oh, I remember that," Duncan nodded as if nothing was out of the ordinary, with a faint look of realization. "I gave that amulet to Mr. Morris —and in the last two days I sent out another one."

As he spoke, he turned around, took another amulet from the shelf behind him, and held it up in front of Vanna.

"Just like this."

Vanna looked at the antique shopkeeper with a strange expression as he openly took his "treasures" off the shelf like mass?produced goods: "You have many of these charm amulets here?"

"I bought a whole crate. Counting the ones I gave away and sold, twenty? one have gone out so far," Duncan nodded in all seriousness. "Are you interested too?"

As he spoke, he could not help giving the young inquisitor another look.

Vanna felt very strange to him today. She looked a bit absent?minded, and her words came out slightly slow. But more than these surface signs, what felt off was her unstable "aura" at this moment.

Duncan could not say what it was, but this young inquisitor now gave him the feeling that there was another person hidden inside her thoughts,

another pair of eyes behind her eyes. She was standing here talking with him, yet deep in her mind something else seemed to be hiding.

Vanna seemed not to notice Duncan's careful gaze. She was only a bit unused to his open way of doing business—though from the start she had known there was nothing truly genuine in this shop: "Uh…no, I am only here to ask about some things. I would like to know the exact supply channel for these charm amulets, and also whether they have ever shown anything special. Have the people who bought them ever reported anything unusual?"

"You mean…"

"Heidi believes that the charm amulet she wore back then gave her real protection and even helped her stay conscious during that disaster," Vanna said briefly, without going into detail. "I think the charm amulet you gave Mr. Morris was very likely touched by some extraordinary power, so I came to investigate. Of course, you do not need to worry. From what we know so far, the influence does not seem to be harmful."

She said this, but left one thing unsaid: an investigation was one thing, but before coming here she had not expected Duncan to have a whole crate of these charm amulets—and to have already sold so many!

Duncan, on the other hand, felt a small jolt in his heart when he heard Vanna's words.

That thing…had really worked? The "gift" he had given away so casually had actually protected that psychiatrist's sense of self?

Why had that happened?

What was the key?

Was it the act of giving the "gift" itself, or was it because that psychiatrist's "inspiration" was unusually high?

Chapter 274: A Pleasant Meeting

At that moment, Duncan went through all the charm amulets he had handed out in recent times. He thought for a long while before finally letting out a small breath of relief.

In his memory, the only charm amulets he had given away as special gifts were the two he gave to Morris. The rest were just ordinary goods, and after all this time, none of the customers who bought charm amulets had come back to report anything strange.

After he relaxed, Duncan could not help falling into thought.

Although the cause of the charm amulet's change was still unclear, the news Vanna brought had clearly served as a warning. It made him more aware, and mentally prepared, for the "weird phenomena" that might appear around him.

From now on… it seemed he could not casually give things to people, nor casually agree to things anymore.

Duncan's brief silence drew Vanna's notice. She looked over at him with curiosity: "Did you remember something?"

"…I went over everything from lately, and nothing seems wrong." Duncan shook his head. His expression stayed calm, but his tone was sincere. "Could it be that Heidi was mistaken?"

"Not likely. She is a senior psychiatrist, she knows something about the supernatural field, and she is very clear about her own mental state." Vanna

shook her head. “But the problem with the charm amulet really could have happened somewhere else… Maybe an supernatural item got mixed in with ordinary goods, or maybe something happened in the manufacturing process…”

Vanna spoke slowly, but it did not sound like she was explaining it to Duncan. It sounded more like she was hypnotizing herself, trying to convince herself.

As an Inquisitor, she should not have been lax about a potential supernatural incident, yet in the end her attention still drifted away from the matter of the charm amulet.

The sound of gentle waves echoed in her mind, bringing wave after wave of calm. It also made her slowly forget why she had come here in the first place.

Vanna raised her head and quietly looked around the antique shop.

The girl named Shirley had already returned to the shop. She was putting things on the shelves while carefully glancing in this direction.

Nina was also in the shop helping out.

The blonde woman named Alice bustled beside the small stove.

Mr. Duncan sat behind the counter with a friendly smile on his face.

The noise of traffic on the street outside sounded a little distant. Inside the shop, the kettle was starting to whistle louder and louder. In a corner of the nearby shelf, some shadows seemed to wriggle and jump. The stairs leading to the second floor looked as if they stretched up into endlessly high darkness.

The whole building seemed filled with faint, almost inaudible whispers.

“The tea is ready.” Alice’s voice came from the side. She brought over a cup of hot tea, set it on the counter, and pushed it toward Vanna. “Please enjoy.”

Vanna silently picked up the cup, raised it to her lips, took a sip, and then started to chew. The scalding tea and tea leaves went down into her stomach as she swallowed, without the slightest change in her expression.

Duncan was almost struck dumb by the sight. It was the first time he had ever seen someone so calm while swallowing down Alice’s tea. Miss Vanna really lived up to her title as Pland’s number-one beauty and tough hero; no ordinary person could compare.

After a while, when he saw that Vanna was only looking around and showed no sign of speaking, Duncan finally could not help breaking the silence: “Besides the charm amulet, was there anything else?”

“Ah, sorry, I spaced out for a moment.” Vanna seemed to wake up all at once, then suddenly coughed hard a few times, as if something had gone down the wrong way. She frowned at the empty teacup in front of her, then shook her head. “No, that was all. I only came to ask about this matter.”

“If you are interested in the charm amulets, I can give you one.” Duncan smiled as he pushed forward the charm amulet he had taken down earlier. “You can take it back and study it slowly.”

Vanna looked in surprise at the “crystal” charm amulet in front of her. She stared for a moment before asking: “How much is it?”

“I’ll just give it to you. It isn’t worth much anyway. I usually throw them in as freebies with other sales,” Duncan said with a half-smile. “Or I can make up a fancy product story for you on the spot. Do you want the ancient artifact version or the health?and?wellness version?”

Vanna was left blinking, completely taken in: “You… sell things here like that?”

“Honest business,” Duncan said, spreading his hands. “If I really sold it, the original price would be eight sola. Add a set of health?and?wellness theory and it becomes sixteen. Add a historical story and it’s twenty?two. If you pay twenty?five, I can throw in a black walnut box—the box comes with a promise that the finish won’t fade for half a year. And I can even write you a receipt for two hundred.”

Vanna had lived in the Upper City since childhood. Before she came of age she entered the Church for training, and once she became an adult she went straight to fighting heretics with a sword. In more than twenty years of life, she had never seen anything like this, and she was a little dazed: “A… receipt for two hundred?”

“You can use it as a gift for coworkers,” Duncan said with a straight face. “And young people can give it to their lovers…”

Vanna thought about it seriously, then shook her head: “Then I probably don’t need that—but I can’t just take your things for free.”

As she spoke, she reached into her clothes, took two ten?sola bills from her pocket, and laid them on the counter.

“Eight sola is the original price—the rest is thanks for your cooperation, and for the tea just now.”

Duncan opened his mouth, wanting to say something more, but saw that Vanna had already stood up and picked up the crystal pendant.

“This was a pleasant meeting.” She slowly showed a smile and suddenly spoke in a very solemn tone as she lifted her hand and put the crystal pendant around her neck. “I look forward to next time.”

Duncan felt she suddenly seemed a bit strange and frowned without thinking, but in the end he did not say more. He just nodded politely: “All right then. You’re welcome to come again.”

Vanna gave a slight nod and turned to leave.

She walked straight through the shop, out the front door, and stepped onto the open space in front of the antique shop, then stopped there.

A series of sharp beeps from a horn suddenly sounded from the roadside nearby.

Vanna blinked. Only then did she notice the car parked by the road, and remember that the Storm Cathedral was arriving in Pland today. She hurried over, opened the door, and got in.

“You finally came out,” the young subordinate waiting in the car said as he quickly started the engine. “It’s been almost an hour and a half. I was thinking that if you still didn’t come out, I’d go in…”

“An hour and a half?” Vanna was a little surprised. “I thought… only forty minutes had passed.”

As she spoke, she tapped her forehead lightly. She felt as if she had forgotten something and could not help muttering under her breath: “I left too quickly just now. I don’t think I even said goodbye.”

“You can do it next time. The shop isn’t going anywhere,” the young subordinate said casually. Then, through the rearview mirror, he saw the crystal charm amulet now hanging on Vanna’s neck and couldn’t help being surprised. “Is that a new pendant you bought? That’s unexpected. You usually don’t buy these things.”

“Pendant?” Vanna lowered her head in confusion and glanced at her chest. After two seconds she spoke, her voice a little hesitant: “Ah… yes, I bought it…”

She shook her head, as if fully awake now.

“Let’s drop it. Drive faster. Go straight to the Harbor.”

…

Inside the antique shop, Shirley was the first to run up to the counter. Uneasy, she glanced back in the direction Vanna had left, then turned to Duncan: “Why did that Inquisitor come here? Was she here to arrest me?”

“You’re overthinking.” Duncan looked at the nervous girl, a helpless look on his face. “She came to investigate something else. It has nothing to do with you.”

“Oh, as long as she wasn’t here to arrest me.” Shirley let out a breath of relief, but then couldn’t help muttering, “She felt weird today. She kept talking in bits and pieces.”

“Maybe it’s the pressure from work,” Duncan said casually as he stood up from behind the counter. “Her direct superior is about to arrive, after all.”

Nina came over at this moment. Hearing Duncan’s words, she reacted at once: “Direct superior… You mean the news from the paper before? The Storm Cathedral?”

Duncan nodded with a smile, his gaze sweeping over Nina, Shirley, and Alice. Then he suddenly asked: “Interested?”

“Interested?” Shirley froze for a moment. When she reacted, her face showed sudden shock. “Wait, you’re not saying you want to go…”

“We won’t have much business today anyway. Most people either went to the cathedrals for mass or to the Harbor to watch. Sitting in the shop doing nothing is still doing nothing,” Duncan said, as if it were obvious. “Let’s go have a look. You don’t get to see the Storm Cathedral docking every year.”

As he finished speaking, Nina had already jumped up happily: “Great!”

Alice, on the other side, did not know what was going on, but when she saw Nina so excited, she started clapping too. Only Shirley wore a look like she

had seen a ghost: “B?but… that’s the Storm Cathedral! If we go over there, won’t we…”

Duncan looked at her, half smiling: “Won’t what?”

Shirley looked up at Duncan, then lowered her head and thought for a moment. She shook her head hard: “Nothing at all!”

Duncan nodded in satisfaction.

Then he lifted his head, his gaze passing over the street outside, over the city blocks, toward Pland’s Harbor.

In his Transcendent Perception that covered the whole city?state, he could already feel a presence, vast and imposing, slowly approaching Pland.

The Storm Cathedral had arrived.

Chapter 275: The Storm Cathedral

In Duncan’s senses, something with an immense presence was slowly drawing near the city?state of Pland.

His perception could not actually leave Pland’s physical bounds and extend outward, but as that immense presence came closer, he could still sense in an indirect way a kind of “radiance”. It was like a heat source, something that shone with strong light, slowly coming into focus on the Boundless Sea.

A simple gigantic ship would not give this feeling, nor would a group of powerful priests.

Duncan narrowed his eyes a little. In the “darkness” outside the city?state of Pland, that mass of strong light and heat was slowly taking shape.

What it was giving off… was that the so?called power of the God?

A moment later, green flames suddenly flared up from a window on the antique shop’s second floor. Then a plump white dove flew out of the window and quickly crossed the sky.

…

Inside and outside the Harbor in the southeast part of Pland, a huge crowd had already gathered.

The Storm Cathedral, which cruised the seas year?round and almost never made port, was about to dock at the city?state. For any believer who followed the storm Goddess Gamona, this was a once?in?a?lifetime grand

event. Whether to show their piety or simply to look upon the Storm Cathedral's majestic form, none of Pland's citizens wanted to miss today's spectacle.

When the Sun rose this morning and the curfew ended, residents living near the Harbor had already begun to gather. By the time it was close to noon, almost every spot near the Harbor that could be used to watch the ceremony was filled.

After that, the area around the Harbor went under traffic control. City Hall no longer allowed more spectators to approach the docks and worked with the Church to guide people to the various sanctuaries.

When the Storm Cathedral docked, mass rituals would also be held at the cathedrals across the city at the same time. On one hand, these rituals were of course to "welcome the Goddess's glory". On the other, they were meant to ease the pressure on the Harbor district and split up the believers.

Beyond the packed crowds, inside the Harbor district itself, lay the "ceremonial area" that the Church Guardians and city constables had temporarily sealed off. The local leadership of the Church and the city's high?ranking officials had gathered there, already prepared to welcome the Storm Cathedral.

After hurrying all the way, Vanna finally reached the Harbor in time.

"You were almost late." Governor Dante, who was waiting at the Harbor to welcome them, glanced at his niece rushing over, his single eye full of helplessness. "On such an important day, you, an Inquisitor, are actually the last to arrive."

"Something unexpected came up." Even as an Inquisitor, Vanna could not keep her usual presence in front of her uncle. With a hint of embarrassment

on her face, she said, “I had planned my time well. I should have arrived at least half an hour early…”

“The Goddess will forgive you,” came the voice of Archbishop Valentine from the side. The elder was dressed in full ceremonial robes, holding the long staff that symbolized the city?state’s bishop. A faint smile rested on his face. “There is still some time before the appointed moment.”

Vanna nodded, let out a small breath, and looked around.

The view around the pier was wide. Guardians and constables had cordoned off a fairly large ceremonial area, but once her gaze went past that open space, she could see countless spectators in the distance, a sea of heads.

In all of Pland, nearly three?quarters of the residents were baptized believers of the Deep Sea Church. Even among the remaining quarter, those who had not been baptized still kept a shallow faith in the storm Goddess Gamona under the influence of the city’s atmosphere.

This city?state was the largest gathering place of Deep Sea believers on the Boundless Sea, and the grand scene before them showed that with overwhelming force.

“The arrival of the Storm Cathedral can actually help us solve a lot of problems,” Dante’s voice reached Vanna’s ears. “With this great event, the unrest in the city can quickly settle down, and we can release the news about the ‘Visions’ more gently. Honestly… I really feel relieved.”

“For believers, ‘being under the God’s gaze’ is more comforting than anything,” Bishop Valentine replied. “With the Goddess’s protection and witness, we can show the greatest unity and resilience, and we can face even extreme cases, including ‘the city becoming a Vision’, with calm.”

“Maybe the Storm Cathedral’s arrival is exactly to help us get through this crisis,” Dante said. “It’s just that Her Holiness the Pope has not said so

outright.”

“Her Holiness has her own reserve. Besides, every message she sends out has to be guided by the God…”

While her uncle and the old bishop spoke beside her, Vanna’s attention slowly left them. She gazed out at the endless sea in the distance, waiting for that towering Cathedral to appear in her sight.

The appointed time was almost here, yet there was still no sign of that astonishing giant ship on the calm sea.

Yet in the very next second, the corner of Vanna’s eye suddenly caught a momentary distortion on the sea.

The sea water curled, the sky trembled, and the sunlight on the waves suddenly rippled out, turning into layers upon layers of cloud?like veils. An engineering construct almost as large as the entire Harbor district abruptly rose onto the sea’s surface, as if it had crossed straight through dimensions to appear in Vanna’s sight!

It had not fully appeared yet and still looked faint and unreal, but its vast, rolling presence was already sweeping toward them, shaking the heart.

Even as the city?state’s Inquisitor, this was Vanna’s first time seeing this ark?ship with her own eyes.

In an instant, feelings of excitement, thrill, and awe rose in her.

She held her breath without thinking, then looked to her side.

The high?ranking officials from City Hall craned their necks in anticipation. Bishop Valentine and her uncle were staring wide?eyed at the distance.

It seemed that the shock and astonishment were so great that they had forgotten to speak.

After another two or three seconds, Bishop Valentine’s eyes lit up. He raised his staff high and brought it down hard. The sound of the staff’s tip striking the ground rang out like thunder across the entire harbor square.

“Praise the name of the Storm!”

The high?ranking priests gathered near the pier answered in unison: “Praise the name of the Storm!”

Salute cannons fired. Magnificent music followed. Cheers thundered in and around the Harbor; everywhere she listened, the whole place boiled with sound.

Vanna looked out to the sea beyond the Harbor and saw that the earlier strange scene of curling water and shifting light had already settled. The majestic Storm Cathedral had dropped all cover and disguise and was slowly drawing close to Pland’s shore.

The gathered crowd was in a frenzy.

Loud benedictions rang out everywhere, cheers and joy were everywhere, and even small children who didn’t understand what was happening were excited in the crowd. Together with the salute cannons and the music, the noise was deafening.

On the roof of a tower near the docks, Duncan stepped out from a door of flames and quietly watched the scene of noisy celebration and the huge cathedral?ark not far away, a structure that already went beyond the idea of a “ship” and made it hard to imagine how it could even move.

Nina and Shirley were beside him, too excited to sit still, noisily arguing about the structure of the cathedral?ark—Nina starting from the mechanical knowledge she had learned at school, while Shirley relied completely on wild imagination and stubborn confidence.

Alice seemed a bit nervous. She had never seen such a huge thing moving on the sea, and when the steam pipes on the side of the cathedral?ark suddenly vented and the loud whistle echoed through the sky, she instantly grabbed her head with both hands.

Duncan’s gaze slowly moved between the crowd gathered at the docks and the cathedral?ark’s towering triple spires.

He closed his eyes, then opened them again.

He saw countless gray?white phantoms spreading out from within the Storm Cathedral, like invisible tentacles or like ribbons of drifting smoke. These flowing shadows stretched out from every door, every window, even every mechanical seam of the cathedral?ark, rolling out in a mass like storm clouds to cover half the sky above Pland.

He saw those drifting shadows droop downward, sweeping over the gathered crowds and the bell?ringing towers.

The phantoms brushed lightly over the heads of the cheering Pland residents, who were clearly unaware of it.

It seemed no one could see those shadows, not even the priests of the Church who had very high Spirit Sight.

Or rather… was it exactly because they were priests of the Church that they could not see those shadows?!

What were these shadows? What were these invisible tentacles spreading out from the Storm Cathedral?

A huge question gathered in his heart. Duncan’s expression grew more and more serious. Without thinking, he reached his hand out into the air beyond the platform, as if trying to catch one of the phantoms.

At the same time, a gray?white phantom like smoke drifted over and slowly approached his palm.

The strip of smoke thickened a little and wrapped around Duncan’s fingers. In the next second, he actually felt a slight, cold touch, as if he had touched some kind of solid thing.

Then the gray?white “tentacle” snapped back at once, leaving only a cold, hollow feeling behind.

Chapter 276: Swift Judgment

The wisp of “smoke” that had briefly brushed against him faded away.

Yet more of the smoke kept leaking out from the Storm Cathedral. It drifted in the air, gathering and scattering, like a dark cloud drawing together above Pland. Its range grew wider and wider, until it slowly spread over half the city-state.

Duncan still felt a trace of cold on his fingertips. He frowned slightly and looked up at the sky over the city, his mind full of questions.

Those gray-white mists gave him a strange feeling… as if some giant being had lost its body, and its soul had risen within the Mortal Realm, turning into this unbound form. At the same time, it felt as if something behind the Mortal Realm was slowly releasing its own perception, using the fog as tentacles to “feel” the outline of the Mortal Realm.

That second feeling had been especially strong when he touched that strand of smoke.

“Uncle Duncan?” Nina’s voice suddenly came from beside him, cutting off Duncan’s wild thoughts. “Why are you holding your hand out like that?”

“…It’s nothing.” Duncan blinked and spoke softly.

Obviously, Nina could not see the smoke. Shirley and Alice beside her could not see it either, and neither could the ordinary people gathered in and around the docks.

But could the people on the Storm Cathedral see it? Could that woman on the Cathedral, the Pope who sat in command there and was seen as the earthly messenger of the Storm Goddess Gamona, see it?

Duncan quietly cast his gaze toward the vast “ark”, almost as large as the entire Harbor district. He watched it slow at the edge of Pland. He watched as the mechanisms along its side slowly shifted, as if growing limbs, extending a long mechanical bridge that reached out to connect with the piers of the Harbor.

During this process, that shapeless and invisible smoke clearly spread even further.

Duncan did not sense any hostility from the mist, nor did he feel that it was dangerous, so for the moment he did nothing.

…

According to the rites, after salutes were fired and music was played in the Harbor of Pland to show welcome, the Storm Cathedral extended the long mechanical bridge, completing the connection between the Pilgrimage Ark and the city-state. Then a second long, solemn blast of the whistle sounded from the ark.

Huge steam valves turned open. All across the Pilgrimage Ark, relief pipes and whistle devices activated at the same time. Jets of white vapor burst from the ramparts and spires of the Cathedral, shooting into the sky along with the whistle.

The bells of the city-state and the bell tower on the Cathedral ark rang together.

Vanna took a deep breath. Standing in such a solemn, awe-inspiring place, even as an Inquisitor she could not help feeling a little nervous.

After another moment, she saw colorful flags appear along the edge of the Cathedral ark. Right after that, a squad of church knights in special armor appeared on the long mechanical bridge. They rode Steam Walkers along the bridge to the dock. One of them stepped out of the line and came straight to the high-ranking priests.

“Bishop Valentine, Inquisitor Vanna. May the glory of the Lord of Storms be with you.”

The knight commander lowered his head. His whole body was covered in black alloy armor. Pressure pipes and steam valves ran across his breastplate and vambraces. A thick steel mask hid the knight’s real face. Vanna could only see the faint red glow in his goggles and hear the hiss of air mixed into his voice.

Steam was the breath of the god, and steel was the bridge between mortals and god. Behind the faceplate, the hiss in his words carried a sacred tone of preaching.

“May the glory of the Lord of Storms be with you.” Vanna lowered her head and spoke together with Bishop Valentine beside her.

“Her Eminence the Pope invites the two of you aboard the ark,” the knight commander said, his words wrapped in hissing air. “The others, please wait here for a while.”

Vanna looked up in surprise, then instinctively turned to Bishop Valentine, only to see the same puzzled look on his face.

Was this part of the formal rites?

“This is a temporary arrangement by the Pope,” the knight commander explained, seeing the confusion on the two high-ranking priests. “She has some things she wishes to ask you.”

“As Your Eminence commands.” Bishop Valentine quickly smoothed the doubt from his features and bowed his head respectfully.

Vanna also came back to her senses and lowered her head to show she accepted the order.

“Please, priests and city officials, wait a moment. You may also go to the side and rest a little,” the knight commander said, nodding slightly to Dante and the others. “Do not worry. It will not take long.”

Vanna and Bishop Valentine stepped onto the mechanical bridge leading to the Storm Cathedral. The grand Cathedral loomed closer and closer in her sight. At the same time, it gave off an even stronger, almost suffocating aura of majesty.

Just walking toward it made Vanna feel her heart start to pound.

Noticing the hesitation in her steps, Bishop Valentine shook his head lightly. “Relax. This is not your first time seeing Her Eminence the Pope.”

“…Yes. I understand.”

Led by a squad of church knights, Vanna and Valentine crossed the long bridge and walked over the connection deck, which was almost as wide as a dock square. At last they were brought into a huge shaft lift.

Vanna had thought the shaft lift would take her to some place on the upper levels of the Cathedral ark. But inside, she felt the entire car sinking instead.

The descent went on for a long time, long enough that Vanna could not help wondering if the shaft lift went straight down into the sea. Only then did the squeaking of the cables suddenly stop.

The door of the shaft lift opened.

A church knight’s voice came from beside them: “Please walk forward on your own. Her Eminence the Pope is waiting for you ahead.”

Still a little dazed, Vanna followed Valentine out of the shaft lift. Behind them, the metal gate slammed shut with a scraping sound. The two of them looked forward and saw a place almost completely covered in darkness.

They could only vaguely make out a richly dressed figure standing in the very dim middle of the room.

Vanna hesitated for a moment, then took a step forward.

As she stepped out, the soft pop of igniting flames suddenly broke the silence in the dark space.

Pop, pop, pop. Several small bursts sounded in a row as braziers were lit one after another. The firelight instantly drove away the darkness around the shaft lift, letting Vanna clearly see Pope Helena standing not far away. It also showed her, in shock, that this place was far larger than she had imagined.

Even with several braziers burning, the distant space was still drowned in shadow. Vanna could not see where this “room” ended. She could only see the gray-black, slightly rough floor stretching out before her, all the way into the dark. At the edge of the firelight, she could faintly make out huge “pillars”, with many crisscrossing shadows between them. They looked like the pipe system at the bottom of the Cathedral ark, or perhaps its support structures.

Was this the lowest hold of the Pilgrimage Ark?

Why would the Pope choose to receive her and Bishop Valentine down here?

Questions rose in Vanna’s heart, but before she could speak, a gentle yet authoritative voice came from ahead: “You have come, Saint Valentine, and

Saint Vanna. Welcome aboard the ark."

"Your Eminence the Pope." Vanna quickly put away the doubts in her heart. After fixing her expression, she saluted together with Bishop Valentine. When the salute was over, she lifted her gaze slightly and asked carefully: "You summoned us here because…"

But Helena did not let Vanna finish. Instead, she suddenly asked a strange question: "Do you know what this place is?"

"Is this… not the Storm Cathedral?" Valentine raised his head and blinked in confusion. "The lower part of the Storm Cathedral?"

"We are indeed directly beneath the Storm Cathedral, but in strict structural terms, this area is no longer part of the Cathedral itself." Helena smiled. In the light of several braziers, there seemed to be a deeper meaning hidden in that smile. "You are standing on the lowest level of the Pilgrimage Ark, in the 'belly' of this giant beast."

She lifted her head, her gaze slowly moving between Vanna and Valentine.

"Here we stand under the gaze of the Lord of Storms, and also at the place closest to the Deep Sea. The Lord's blessing and the Lord's judgment coexist here."

Helena's gaze came to a stop, but she was not looking at Vanna or Valentine.

It was as if she was speaking to the empty darkness.

"After one's faith wavers, is it very hard to keep fulfilling one's duties?"

The expression on Vanna's face froze at once.

Valentine's did as well.

An almost unbearable tension filled this wide, dim space.

After an unknown time, Vanna was the first to react. She took a deep breath. “My faith…”

“I did not ask about your faith.” Helena shook her head. “I asked whether, after your faith wavered, it has become harder than before for you to continue carrying out your duties.”

Vanna was stunned for a moment, as if she had not yet grasped the deeper meaning in the Pope’s words. Beside her, Bishop Valentine looked suddenly enlightened after a brief shock. The old bishop spoke at once: “I have carried out my duties as always. Protecting the city-state and guiding the believers all come from my own heart…”

“Good, Saint Valentine. Your steadfastness moves me. You shall continue to carry out your duties as Protector of the city-state of Pland until the end.

“Saint Vanna, I have also seen your confusion. In light of your actual situation, I must announce the temporary suspension of your office as Inquisitor of Pland.

“This decision takes effect immediately.”

Helena spoke so fast that she finished before Vanna and Valentine could react.

The two Saints on the spot stared at each other.

Valentine: “…?”

Vanna: “…?”

Chapter 277: A New Storm

Vanna and Valentine both stood there in a daze at this sudden turn of events. Pope Helena's "judgment" felt less like a solemn religious ruling and more like something carried out just to reach a set result. The result had already been decided; what they had just said was only a formality.

Such a hasty "ruling" was, of course, hard for Vanna the Inquisitor to accept. Even Valentine at her side could not accept it. They spoke at the same time: "Your Eminence the Pope…"

"Enough, enough. It is not such a bad thing. Life is always full of rises and falls, just like storms are always the hardest to predict." Helena waved her hand, cutting off Vanna and Valentine. "And do not sink into loss so easily, Saint Vanna. Laying down the duties of an Inquisitor is not necessarily a punishment. It only means you are, for now, not suited to this job. Perhaps… the storm has other favor in store for you."

Vanna paused. She seemed to catch a faint hint of something in Helena's tone. But just as she was about to ask, she saw the Pope shake her head at her.

"Let us stop here for now. There are other things I must see with my own eyes before I can decide," Helena said calmly. "Pland… It has been many years since I last set foot on this land myself."

She paused for a moment.

"You two go back to the upper deck first. The shaft lift is ready. I will complete a benediction here. It will not take long. We will meet on the

upper deck.”

Before she even knew what was happening, Vanna found herself being “sent” back into the shaft lift together with Valentine. Only when the shaft lift reached the top, when they stepped out of the car and were walking along the corridor toward the upper deck, did Valentine finally break the silence in a low voice: “Vanna, how… do you feel now?”

He really could not think of any better way to break the awkward mood.

Vanna stopped walking.

Valentine stepped a little to the side.

“You stepped away two paces. Are you serious?”

“I am afraid you are serious.”

“You can still crack dry jokes, so it seems you have also noticed how strange this is.” Vanna shook her head and spoke softly. “To be honest, my first reaction was disbelief and refusal. Such a rushed and careless ‘ruling’ feels more like a bad joke, and not something that should come from the mouth of Her Eminence the Pope. But then I went back over her words in my mind, and I keep feeling… she had some deeper intent.”

As she spoke, she let out a light breath. “I think I should be patient and wait —for the ‘special favor of the storm’ that Her Eminence spoke of.”

“Your calm and reason really are far above most people. When something like this suddenly falls on their head, most people would not be able to think it through as quickly as you have,” Valentine said, stepping forward again as they walked. “But more than that, there is something else I care about right now.”

Vanna frowned a little. “Something else?”

“When an Inquisitor is removed, a new Inquisitor has to take over. A post as important as city-state Inquisitor must be personally ‘tested’ and appointed by the Pope. You know that process very well,” Valentine said slowly. “But Her Eminence the Pope did not mention this at all. It should have been a ‘necessary matter’ announced along with your removal, or even in advance.”

Vanna subconsciously frowned again, but did not speak at once. Valentine went on: “Also, she chose to announce your removal in a ‘secret chamber’ known to no one. By church law, the secrets given by the Pope in a secret room must not be spoken by any other mouth, no matter what those secrets are. This serves as a kind of ‘safety signal’.”

Vanna had to admit that, as young as she was, she did not know the Storm Canon as deeply as an experienced priest like Bishop Valentine did. She had not thought of these key points at all.

“You mean…”

“No one will know about your removal,” Valentine said softly, looking calmly into Vanna’s eyes. “And no new Inquisitor will come to take over your post.”

Vanna blinked, her brows knitting. “Then how am I supposed to keep doing my duty in Pland?”

“I do not know,” Valentine said quietly. He lifted his head to look toward the end of the corridor ahead. After thinking a moment, he added, “But I suspect you may soon no longer need to carry out your duties in Pland.”

…

In the vast space below, Pope Helena stood quietly among the dim firelight. After a long time, she finally lifted her head and looked toward the distant darkness.

This was the very bottom of the Pilgrimage Ark, an area that ordinary people almost never had a chance to see and could not even imagine. She called it the “belly of the giant beast”, and in a sense, that was not wrong at all.

Helena started walking. She passed the burning braziers and reached a place that had not been lit by the fire before.

Clusters of flame spread out with her steps, slowly lighting up the whole dark space and revealing what had been hidden.

Vein-like patterns twisted across the floor. From the high dome hung huge tumor-like masses or nerve nodes. Nerve bundles and vascular pillars dangled from the dome, along with great pale supports that looked like bones.

All these things that had been swallowed by darkness now appeared before Helena’s eyes as the firelight spread.

She finally stopped in front of a huge “pillar”.

It was a pillar formed by many complex structures winding and piling together. Its surface was uneven, wrapped all over with nerve fibers and vascular systems like relief carvings. Deep within those nerves, she could faintly see tangled metal wires and silver needles glittering, as if they had crept down from the layers above.

At the top of this pillar, on the dim dome, even more dense hanging organs could be seen. Their surfaces were full of ridges and grooves, looking very much like… brains.

Helena stared at the pillar for a long time. Then she reached out and slowly stroked the ridged grooves formed by the nerve fibers.

“The Truth Academy… truly unbelievable craft,” she murmured in praise. “Who would have thought that a dead Leviathan could be ‘brought back’ in

this way…”

As soon as she finished speaking, a low, squirming sound came from within the pillar. A hoarse, old voice then rose from some unknown structure inside it: “First of all, I was not exactly dead from the start. Second, I do not think what I am now counts as ‘alive’ either. Using life and death to describe a Leviathan is not very precise, young lady.”

“…I thought you were asleep.”

“I am asleep most of the time. But today you prayed so formally to Queen Gamona, and you even brought outsiders down here. I felt I should at least stay awake.”

The corner of Helena’s mouth seemed to twitch. “…Then did you like what you saw?”

“I think you are rather heartless,” the hoarse old voice replied again. “She has done very well. In the combined ratings of Inquisitors from all the city-states, none have surpassed her. And yet you just dismissed her. Do not talk about wavering faith as an excuse. We both know that as long as one can keep doing the job, that reason is the least important of all.”

“This is the arrangement of the Lord of Storms.” Helena spoke quietly.

The hoarse old voice paused noticeably before speaking again: “…Oh. Then I have no problem with it.”

Helena shook her head helplessly. “I thought you would at least ask a few more questions.”

But this time, the hoarse old voice gave no reply at all.

He had fallen asleep.

…

On the boundless expanse of the Boundless Sea, the ironclad warship The Sea Mist was cutting through the waves. As the warship slowly “healed” and now ran at full power, the thin layer of icy mist returned around the hull, constantly forming small bits of floating ice on the nearby sea.

Tyrian went to the bow and looked out over the open water ahead.

For some reason, a vague unease had been nagging at him.

At first, he thought it was the lingering “damage from being beaten by his father”, the stress built up from seeing his father several times near Pland’s coast and inside the city. But as The Sea Mist sailed farther and farther from Pland, the unease not only failed to fade, it grew even stronger.

It even left him slowly growing a little irritable.

It felt as if something was about to happen—or had already happened—and that it was very likely connected to him.

As an supernatural, he trusted his intuition in such matters.

Tyrian took a deep breath and pressed his hand on the rail in front of him, frowning in thought.

Just then, as if to confirm his growing unease, hurried footsteps suddenly sounded behind him.

Tyrian turned sharply and saw First Mate Aiden hurrying toward him.

The first mate, usually so calm, now had clear worry on his face.

Tyrian frowned at once. “What happened?”

“The chapel on board just received a Psychic Transmission from home port. Something happened in the waters near Frostholm…”

“Near Frostholm?” Tyrian felt his heart skip a beat and pressed on, “What is the situation?”

“…An ancient diving device suddenly appeared in the waters off Frostholm,” Aiden said, drawing in a breath as he spoke. “It is Submersible No. 3—the eighth one.”

Chapter 278:

The veil of night was sinking deeper, and the cold World's Wound already hung high in the night sky. Under its pale glow, the entire city-state fell into silence.

On the second floor of the antique shop in the Lower City, Duncan stood at the small window at the end of the hallway. He quietly looked out at the silent street, at the uneven rooftops under the cold light, and at the pipes and valves that crossed the district above those roofs.

In another, distant sight, he could see the Vanished crossing the rolling waves of the Boundless Sea. The ship was sailing north through the night, chasing in the direction where the Sea Mist had gone.

Here in Pland, he extended his gaze over the entire city-state. Using that omnipresent sense, he scanned every corner of Pland.

He lifted his eyes a little and saw that the invisible "mists" were still floating above the city.

Those soul-like "smokes" released by the great storm Cathedral had stopped expanding after nightfall. Now they barely covered three quarters of Pland. They rose and fell slowly in the night sky like a thin veil, as if they were…

Taking a leisurely walk through the night sky.

Duncan withdrew his gaze from the sky and turned his attention to that enormous mass of Shadows at the edge of the city-state.

That was where the great storm Cathedral lay anchored.

The enormous Pilgrimage Ark clung to Pland's southeastern Harbor like a dark cloud. In Duncan's senses he could clearly feel the outline of this huge body, but he could not push his probing gaze into the interior of that great Cathedral.

For him, the inside of that great Cathedral was like an empty, dark black hole.

The ordinary ships moored in the Harbor could not block his senses at all. Within a range close enough to Pland, nothing could escape this kind of "touch" from him. Yet this great Cathedral was clearly an exception.

Was it because of Goddess Gamona's "protection"? Or because of some special shielding used by the Deep Sea Church?

Duncan was a little curious, but he did not take any excessive action. He had indeed considered just blasting it once with the green flame to see if he could break the storm Cathedral's defenses, but he only thought about it. After all, they had no grudges between them. There was no need to set fire to someone's house just to satisfy his curiosity.

At that moment, Duncan suddenly felt something. He quickly withdrew his senses from the storm Cathedral and lifted his head to look toward the Upper City.

He gazed thoughtfully at the hills that rose above the surrounding terrain and at Pland Cathedral standing in the night.

…

High in Pland Cathedral, a lounge was brightly lit. Pope Helena lit ritual candles mixed with spices and set the candlestick before a full-length mirror in the corner. Then she tilted her head slightly and looked at Vanna, who had been standing at her side for a long time.

“I heard that the first time you saw ‘him’ in a dream, your first reaction was to leap at him with a full-force jumping slash. What were you thinking at the time?”

A hint of embarrassment appeared on Vanna’s face as she said: “At the time… I didn’t really think about it.”

“When you say ‘I didn’t really think about it,’ it usually means ‘I didn’t think at all,’” Helena said with a smile. “That is actually good. Excellent Warriors usually let action move faster than thought. It is very useful when fighting Heretics and Malevolent Spirits—after all, ‘thinking’ itself can easily become our weakness.”

“…But I only feel lucky that my reckless move didn’t cause any consequences,” Vanna sighed helplessly. “Looking back, he didn’t seem to care about my ‘offense’ at all.”

“He doesn’t care. None of Them care,” Helena said softly. “Higher Beings care about broader, longer things… The good news is, our survival is at least included somewhere in what They care about.”

For a moment Vanna did not respond. Helena looked at this “Inquisitor” who was no longer an Inquisitor, smiling faintly, and said: “Vanna, you must have many questions you want to ask.”

“I want to know… what arrangements you have for me,” Vanna hesitated, then finally spoke. “You secretly removed me from my position as Inquisitor and still have not appointed a new guardian for the city-state. I feel a bit at a loss. I don’t know how I’m supposed to carry out my duty next.”

Helena listened calmly, without the slightest surprise on her face. When Vanna finished, the Pope, who still looked rather young, just smiled and turned to glance out the window.

Through the window framed with wrought-iron patterns, the city streets lit by countless gas lamps looked peaceful and calm.

“It is a very quiet night, Vanna,” the Pope said. “How many incidents of supernatural corruption or eldritch intrusion do you think tonight’s patrolling Guardians will report?”

Vanna froze for a moment, then spoke hesitantly: “…I’m not sure. The city-state really has been relatively safe these days, with hardly any incident reports, but…”

“Zero,” the Pope interrupted. “Tonight there will be zero incidents—just like yesterday, the day before yesterday, and tomorrow as well.”

Vanna opened her mouth.

“You have obviously noticed it too, but you still don’t dare draw a conclusion, do you?” Helena smiled and said: “A city whose nights are no longer dangerous. Even in the temporary darkness after the gas lamps go out, no Shadows grow anymore. The brightest pearl on the Boundless Sea has finally lived up to its name.”

Vanna finally began to catch up: “You mean…”

“Vision-Pland,” Helena nodded lightly. “Inside this large Vision, it seems there are no supernatural corruption phenomena other than Vision-Pland itself.”

“This is your conclusion from observation?”

“Did you think I came here only to let the citizens ‘pay their respects’ on the streets, and to accept greetings from priests and Officials in the great Cathedral?” Helena looked at Vanna with a half-smile. “I have my own ways of observing and judging the changes happening in this city-state.”

Vanna stood there with her mouth slightly open. It felt as if she had countless things to say, yet she suddenly did not know where to start. Messy, tangled thoughts filled her head. She only felt that what was happening once again went beyond her worldview, so much that her old logic could not even find a way to continue the conversation. After who knew how long, she finally blurted out: “So… Pland doesn’t need an Inquisitor anymore?”

“I’m not sure,” Helena said, surprising Vanna. The Pope shook her head, clearly uncertain herself. “This kind of thing has truly never happened before. But at least one point is clear: as long as the nature of Vision-Pland does not change, you really no longer need to work the way you used in the past. The duties of the city-state Guardians will also change greatly.”

Helena paused here, then went on, thinking as she spoke: “Even so, the city-state still needs the protection of Guardians. For now I can only be sure that inside Vision-Pland there will be no ‘naturally occurring supernatural corruption.’ But the threats we face are not limited to natural phenomena. Heretic elements, ancient Spawn, evil creations, those madmen who actively want to destroy the order of civilization will not stay quiet just because Pland has turned into a Vision.

“But overall, one thing is certain: Pland has become much safer.”

Helena stopped. Her gaze stayed calm as she met Vanna’s eyes, and after a few seconds she spoke again in a gentle voice: “Vanna, we are walking a very new path. No city-state and no Church has ever faced a situation like this.

“On the other hand, our world itself… seems to be undergoing some unsettling changes. Whether it is the ‘malfunction’ of Vision 001 or the movements of the Vanished, both are breaking the fragile balance that the city-states have maintained for thousands of years. In such a situation, the

Goddess has given only very limited revelation… I can only act within this limited revelation.

“Vanna, you have great talent, and that talent should be placed in… somewhere more valuable. Pland is now in its safest state, but I don’t think you are someone who likes to sink into comfort, are you?”

Hearing the Pope’s words, Vanna instinctively straightened her back at once: “I am always ready to sacrifice everything for faith and justice!”

“Sacrifice everything?”

“Of course, everything!”

“And you would do anything without hesitation?”

“As long as it is the Goddess’s will!”

“Including going aboard the Vanished?”

“Including…”

Vanna started to answer loudly on instinct, but she choked after just a few words and almost lost her breath. Two seconds later she stared wide-eyed at the Pope before her and said: “What did you… just say, Your Eminence?”

“I said that our world is undergoing many disturbing changes, and among all these changes, the Vanished is at least the only one that has shown the possibility of communication and a tendency toward goodwill,” Helena said solemnly. “We need to establish a stable channel of communication with the master of the Vanished, and it is best if it has some official nature. You can consider yourself an Envoy, or you can see yourself as a ‘hostage’—personally I suggest you use the first description, but how you think about it is up to you.”

Vanna listened, dumbfounded. Only when the Pope finished did she finally find a chance to speak: “B-but… is that even reasonable? Going onto the

Vanished… Is that what I think it means? Is that even possible?!”

Helena quietly watched the young, flustered “Inquisitor,” as if she had long expected this reaction. After a while she smiled and said: “It is reasonable.”

Chapter 279:

Compared to Vanna’s flustered confusion, Pope Helena remained calm from start to finish. She wore a smile, and that smile even seemed a little pleased.

Vanna, however, could not feel pleased at all—she could not see how any of this was “reasonable”!

“I think… this is far too sudden,” the young Inquisitor was racking her brains. She had no idea why the topic had suddenly veered in such a strange direction, and she was trying her best to make her logic catch up with the speeding carriage. “I understand the need to establish contact with the Vanished, but I think it should be done step by step. And if it is only for communication, we already have a way. That Captain Duncan…”

“He visits in dreams or speaks to you through mirrors, doesn’t he?” Helena interrupted gently. “I know. You mentioned it in your reports.”

“Then…”

“That is not enough,” Helena said with a smile, shaking her head. “That is only ‘conversation’, private conversation between you and Captain Duncan. This kind of channel has neither special status nor binding force. It is far from an official channel between the Deep Sea Church and the Vanished. Vanna, you should understand the difference.”

Vanna’s lips moved a few times. A thousand words surged to her throat, but in the end nothing came out.

She had already confirmed that this was not a joke, nor was it some whim of the “God’s Herald” before her. From Helena’s attitude and eyes, Vanna sensed something carefully thought out, and… some feelings she could not yet understand.

After a while she suddenly asked: “The Goddess’s will?”

“You can understand it that way—if it makes you feel any better.”

“…I understand,” Vanna took a light breath and finally calmed herself completely. She returned to her usual strict demeanor and lowered her head with a serious face. “Then I will obey this arrangement.”

“Go rest first,” Helena nodded lightly. “There is still much to do tomorrow.”

Vanna bowed her head again to accept the order, then turned and left the room.

Helena watched the tall figure of the young Inquisitor disappear beyond the door. Only after a long time did she pull back her gaze. Then she suddenly chuckled and shook her head with a hint of helplessness: “This child… She didn’t even ask how I plan to send her to that ship, and she still tried to pretend to stay calm…”

A steady, imposing voice sounded from the side at that moment, mixed with the crackling of leaping flames: “I am curious too. How do you plan to send her onto the Vanished?”

In front of the full-length mirror in the corner of the room, the flames on several candlesticks suddenly turned deep green. The eerie light lit up the mirror. The surface inside became dark and bottomless, and amid the phantom flames that spread quickly, Duncan’s figure stepped out from the depths of that darkness, quietly fixing his gaze on Helena standing in the room.

Helena did not turn around. Even after hearing Duncan's voice behind her, she still quietly gazed out the window and said: "Ah, you were watching after all."

"I couldn't help it. The abacus you are shaking is too loud. The beads are bouncing right into my face."

"…What is an abacus?"

"It's a Subspace joke," Duncan said with a straight face. After all this time, he had already grown used to occasionally making things up in the middle of a conversation. Watching people's confused reactions had become his greatest joy in the process. As for how the other side filled in the blanks afterward…

Anyway, whenever he spoke to people in this world, they always made up their own explanations.

Helena very wisely did not ask further. She still did not turn around and drew all changes in her emotions back inside. Her tone remained calmly gentle as she said: "You probably don't need it, but I will introduce myself anyway—Helena, a humble servant of the storm Goddess Gamona. I am pleased to speak with you."

"Duncan Abnomar, captain of the Vanished," Duncan replied casually. "I like straightforward conversation, so let's be open—what is your goal, or rather, what exactly does the Deep Sea Church want to do?"

"We are only focused on maintaining the order of the civilized world and responding to all the unsettling changes across it," Helena answered lightly. "You should already have heard what I said to Vanna just now. This world is changing—and in fact, the situation is far more serious than what I told her.

“Many Shadows are drawing close to the dimension of our Mortal Realm. The abnormal behavior of Vision 001 may only be the beginning. The destructive actions of the Ender in Pland may be only one part of another great conspiracy. In the north, some city-states have sent disturbing news. At the borders, the Veil is becoming more and more unstable. Within the borders of civilization, Border Collapse incidents are happening with increasing frequency. And among all these changes, the Vanished may be the only one with which there is hope of rational communication.

“We hope to establish stable, effective communication with you. Just as you want to know the goals of the Deep Sea Church, we… also want to know about the Vanished. Since that is the case, why not build a bridge?”

Duncan frowned and said: “So you confidently arranged for Vanna to become this bridge. It’s a fine idea, but how do you know I will agree?”

“You care about her and have helped her before. From the intentions you have shown, you are also very interested in today’s civilized world,” Helena said. “You have regained your reason and humanity, so you have the need to rebuild ties with the civilized world. In my view, Vanna is very suitable for this role—or would you rather trust some ‘strange Messenger’ randomly chosen by the Deep Sea Church?”

“…True. Vanna at least counts as an ‘acquaintance’ of mine. From your perspective, sending her over is the best way to keep the Messenger safe,” Duncan said slowly. “But even so, are you really not worried that sending Vanna onto the Vanished will be like sending a sheep into a tiger’s mouth? Given the fine reputation my ship and I have in the civilized world, if your actions were made public, people might find it more reasonable to see them as a bloody sacrificial rite.”

Helena fell silent for a few seconds. At last she slowly turned around and fixed her gaze on the mirror where green flames were now rippling.

“That is why this matter will not be made public. Apart from the people of Pland, most people in this world still cannot talk about the Vanished with a straight face. Vanna will become a Secret Envoy. Those who know about this will be limited to the upper ranks of the Deep Sea Church and a small number of City-State Governors—or other necessary informed parties when the situation requires it.”

Helena lifted her eyes and gazed at Duncan’s figure in the mirror.

Shimmering, twisted starlight filled her field of vision.

“As for your ‘sheep into a tiger’s mouth’… I am not worried.”

Indescribable, flowing starlight kept swelling and pulsing across the surface of the mirror, as if trying to break through that fragile layer of glass. Fine black cracks spread from the mirror’s edge and crawled across it, and their presence seemed to fill the whole room. Deep, chaotic roars filled her head, and every roar seemed to carry endless knowledge from Subspace.

“I can hear your voice. Your voice is full of calm reason. I believe you truly have regained your humanity. That humanity is proof that you stand on the side of civilization and order.”

In her sight the mirror seemed to turn into a vortex. The starlit giants inside it had completely lost their shapes. All Helena saw was endless starlight. Broken fragments of light exploded in her mind, but in the next second, gentle waves sounded in her head and reshaped her thoughts that were on the verge of falling apart.

“You are friendly and trustworthy. My God has given guidance, and I believe in my God unconditionally. Since He ordered me to work with you, I will act accordingly.”

The crawling starlight in the mirror overflowed. A stream of light flowed out into the air, stretching and pulsing. It swayed slowly in front of Helena,

as if studying prey, yet also as if sniffing the air of the room. The light-shape formed from the writhing starlight leaned to within half a meter of Helena's face, and its countless specks seemed filled with unnumbered eyes.

Through the mirror, Duncan carefully studied Helena's expression. He tried to read the Deep Sea Pope's true intentions from the details of her words and actions. In the end, he found only calm and honesty in her eyes.

After a long time, he withdrew his gaze.

"Then the agreement is made. I will keep a place for Vanna on the Vanished. But in return, once she is on the Vanished, she will be one of my Crew Members. She will act under strict rules whose priority will even stand above her identity in the Church. I hope you understand that."

He did his best to speak with a stiff, imposing air, making the matter sound formal and businesslike.

But inside, he was delighted.

Ever since long ago he had thought that Vanna had a connection with the Vanished. Back then he had already been planning how to coax this high-ranking Cleric onto his ship as a fighter, but he never found a suitable chance or excuse. He had not expected the opportunity to fall from the sky like this.

The Deep Sea Church needed a formal channel to learn the intentions of the Vanished, which would ease their unease. The Vanished also needed a bridge that could communicate with the Church forces of the civilized world, which would help Duncan's future actions. It was something that pleased everyone.

"I understand," Helena nodded slowly. "Then the agreement is made."

Chapter 280: Before the New Recruit Joined

Was what Helena had said really her true thinking? Was the Deep Sea Church's goal really only to build contact with the Vanished? Did this "God's Herald" truly believe in Captain Duncan's humanity and reason the way she claimed?

Duncan did not dare believe it all. Although this female pope's attitude looked very sincere, he had a clear sense of things. He knew the Vanished was famous across the seas and had an impressive "battle record". That fearsome name alone made it impossible for a leader like Helena to deal with him without any guard up—she had to be holding something back.

But caution was not always a bad thing. Choosing to cooperate while staying on guard meant she had a reason she had to work with him. Maybe it was the will of her god. Maybe it was for the Church's interests. Whatever the reason, the olive branch she was offering now was real.

"Since we have already reached an agreement, we should talk about the actual handover and registration process for personnel," Duncan thought for a moment, then spoke to the pope before him from a very reasonable angle. "I think we need some formal documents."

Helena froze at once. Although she was the one who had first raised the matter, she had clearly never thought this far. Her expression now showed some surprise: "Registration… process? What do you mean?"

“Bringing a crew member on board and handing over work is a very serious matter,” Duncan said with a straight face. “The Vanished is an expedition ship with strict personnel management. Your Deep Sea Church is also a proper organization. You send an envoy over and do not even prepare a letter of introduction? And there is also the question of Vanna’s living expenses on the ship, or wear and tear on her personal gear. Whose side should reimburse that? We need to make it clear. Personally I think your side should cover it, at least cover part of it…”

Helena suddenly began to understand what Vanna meant in all those reports where she kept saying “Captain Duncan often does unexpected things”. She had drafted so many plans for dealing with the Vanished, and somehow had never considered this point at all!

“…The Deep Sea Church will of course cover this part of the… ‘budget’,” Helena finally nodded after holding back for a few seconds. “If you need formal paperwork, we can provide it. Or you can provide it—do you have a template on your side?”

“Of course I do. In a bit I can send a messenger to deliver it to you,” Duncan nodded solemnly, his tone very serious. “The Vanished is not some third-rate eldritch god’s lair where you light two braziers, mutter a few words, then shove someone in and call the sacrificial rite a success. We are a very proper employer. Recruitment, rules and regulations, and team-building are all first-class by Subspace standards…”

Helena had been listening with a blank face from the start. Now she could only nod along on reflex. For some reason, she suddenly felt that the twisted starlight in the mirror before her, which kept swelling and shrinking as it squirmed, did not seem quite so dizzying anymore.

She even felt those spinning lights and shadows were a little friendly.

In this slightly dazed state, she finally managed to end her conversation with that ghost captain.

With a soft crackling sound like fire burning, the green flames leaping before the mirror finally faded. Bright yellow-white fire once again rose on the candles. The shifting lights at the edge of the mirror, and the pitch-black cracks that had been everywhere in the room, slowly vanished from her sight.

The stable world of the Mortal Realm appeared before Helena once more.

But she still stared hard at the mirror that had returned to normal, at the reflection that slowly came into view within it.

She did not know how long it took before the trembling lines at the edge of that image finally steadied. Helena then drew in a deep breath, and her tense muscles relaxed bit by bit.

Only now did she feel how the sweat had soaked through her clothes. Her heart was pounding. A hollow, numb ache throbbed in her head.

"…I should remind Vanna to control her curiosity a little in this 'new post'," Helena rubbed her forehead and spoke softly while fighting the dull pain in her head. "Facing Subspace directly… feels terrible."

A sudden crackling sound reached her ears, and a flash of green light entered her sight.

Helena jolted awake, but only had time to see a flicker of green flame flash by the windowsill. She quickly walked toward where the firelight had faded and saw an old parchment sheet lying quietly on the sill.

It was Vanna's registration dossier for the Vanished.

"…He really sent it."

The pope muttered in some shock.

…

The next morning.

“We will be adding a new member.”

In the dining hall of the Vanished, Duncan had gathered everyone on board, including Shirley, who had been helping out in the antique shop, and Morris, the old scholar who had been in the city-state library doing research. Then he solemnly announced this news.

Nina had been holding a handful of fries and feeding the pigeons with great focus. When she heard what Uncle Duncan said, she froze, lifted her head, and stared in surprise: “A new member? Who is it?”

“In a certain sense, she counts as an acquaintance,” Duncan said with a smile, his gaze sweeping along both sides of the table. “You have all met her. Shirley, you and Nina even saw her again not long ago.”

Shirley looked a bit blank. It took her several seconds to slowly realize something, and her expression changed in a way that was visible to the naked eye: “C-could it be that inquisitor…”

“It is her,” Duncan nodded lightly. “Inquisitor Vanna will become a new member of the Vanished, within the next day or two.”

“Clang!”

A loud crash suddenly came from beside the dining table. Duncan calmly looked toward the sound and saw Dog sprawled on the floor in a mess—only a second ago Dog had been sitting on the chair next to Shirley.

Shirley herself had almost fallen off her chair just now. At this moment she glared at Dog and scolded: “Dog, you scared me!”

“I-I-I’m completely dog-dumb here, really, Mr. Duncan, what did you just say—that inquisitor?!” Dog scrambled up off the floor in a panic, ignoring

Shirley’s loud yelling beside him. His two bloody, hollow eye sockets stared at Duncan. “Are you planning to tie that inquisitor up and bring her here? Oh, of course I’m not doubting that you could do it. You could definitely tie her up. But making that inquisitor submit won’t be easy. She has clearly gone through very harsh training, and her head is full of faith in the Storm Goddess. I’m afraid ordinary methods could never make her…”

“…Why was your first thought to tie someone to the ship?” Duncan’s eye twitched. “I said Vanna would become our new member. When did I say anything about tying her to the ship?”

“Then how else do you get her here if you don’t tie her up?” Dog was utterly baffled. In his “normal logic”, he could not think of any other reason why a city-state inquisitor would suddenly become a new member of the Vanished. “Oh, you mean you’ll lock her up on the shore first…”

“Can’t it just be normal crew onboarding and a regular transfer of posts?” Duncan looked expressionlessly at the ugly dog head across from him. “For example, the Deep Sea Church writes a letter of recommendation. I write a notice of employment. Then Vanna, through this completely normal process, becomes the ship’s marine squad member and ship’s priest. Don’t you think that sounds more reasonable?”

Dog thought about it and felt that once you put this kind of “reasonable” thing on the Vanished, it became so bizarre it was almost supernatural. He would rather believe that one day he would open his eyes on the ship and see the Abyssal Lord than believe that series of steps the captain had just described. But after holding it in for a long time, he still did not dare say any of that out loud.

Because this was the Vanished.

And on this ship, the captain was always right.

“You are right,” Dog muttered in a muffled voice, his head drooping. “That is very reasonable.”

Duncan nodded in satisfaction. Then he looked again at the people on both sides of the table. After thinking for a moment, he still decided to add an explanation: “This is an agreement between me and the Deep Sea Church. Vanna will board this ship as a secret envoy, and before her mission ends she will serve under me as a crew member. Her status is a little different from yours, but while we are on the ship, everyone follows the same rules. I hope you can all get along.”

“As long as she doesn’t come looking for trouble with me,” Shirley muttered, “I wouldn’t dare cause trouble for her.”

“I still can’t picture how a city-state inquisitor is supposed to just sit still on this ship,” Dog grumbled along. “I have a feeling life is going to get exciting.”

“I am ready,” Morris, on the far side of the table, nodded lightly. The old scholar looked the calmest of them all (Alice, who had not reacted from beginning to end, did not count), and there was even a strange smile on his face. “Though she may be especially shocked when she sees me… But she will adapt. Vanna has been very good at adapting ever since she was a child.”

Nina had not said much from the start. She had just been thinking about something. Only now did she suddenly lift her head: “Uncle, does that mean we are going to have work to do next?”

Duncan lowered his head: “Why are you asking that all of a sudden?”

“Because you specially called all of us to the ship,” Nina thought for a moment. “Miss Vanna hasn’t even come aboard yet, but you called us in advance, so you must have other plans, right?”

Duncan looked at Nina’s shining eyes (with 6000°C burning deep in them). After a long moment, he smiled and patted her hair.

“Yes, we are going to be busy—we are heading for Frostholm.”

Chapter 281: The Taboos of Reading at Sea

After his long talk with Tyrian, Duncan had already told Nina, Shirley, and the others the intelligence he had gathered about the Abyssal Trench Project. But at the time he had not mentioned what voyage the Vanished would undertake next—until now, when a letter from an old friend to Morris finally led to this journey north.

“We are now sailing north along the Sea Mist’s route. In a few days we should reach the edge of the Frost Sea. The scenery there will be completely different from the Central Seas,” Duncan said. “You can spend this time on the ship. Alice has already prepared rooms for you. Of course, if you find it hard to adapt to life at sea, you can return to the city-state—I can call you over when necessary.”

“I-I’ll stay on the ship,” Shirley raised her hand at once. “I can help Miss Alice with some work…”

“You still have to do your homework on the ship,” Duncan gave her a calm look. “And I will supervise you in person.”

Shirley shrank her neck at once: “Ah, then I…”

“You also have to do your homework in the city-state. And it would still be me supervising you.”

Shirley pulled a long face: “Then… then I’ll stay on the ship. I’ll treat it as a change of scenery.”

“I want to stay on the ship too,” Nina looked at Shirley, then at Duncan. Her eyes were bright, and there was a clear eagerness in her voice. “I still haven’t really gotten used to life on the ship. Last time I didn’t even last until night…”

Duncan nodded: “All right. Then you can go back home later and bring the bedding you are used to over here, so you don’t lose sleep in a strange environment.”

“Mm, mm,” Nina nodded again and again. Then she seemed to remember something and asked, a little hesitant: “Then can I also bring my holiday homework and textbooks to the ship? I’m afraid I won’t finish them before school starts…”

As soon as Nina finished speaking, Dog could not help covering his head with his paws: “We are riding the most terrifying ghost ship in history to resolve an supernatural incident, but somehow it is starting to sound more and more like a holiday trip…”

Duncan did not pay attention to Dog’s muttering. He thought for a moment, then spoke to Nina with some uncertainty: “Shirley and Alice’s spelling books can be brought on board, but your textbooks and homework might be a bit dangerous. Reading books on the Boundless Sea is like reading in the city-state after nightfall. It easily draws malice from the Shadows.”

Nina stared for a moment. She calmly analyzed it, thought a little, then suddenly raised a very constructive question that even Duncan had not considered: “Then if something comes out of the Shadows, can’t you just beat it up?”

Duncan: “…?”

Dog and Shirley: “…Right!”

“I never thought of that,” Duncan said after staring blankly for several seconds, his expression turning strange at last. He had to admit that from the very moment he heard Goathead talk about these ‘taboos of reading at sea’, he had fallen into a mental blind spot. He had simply treated it as a rule, just like everyone else, and had not thought about other options. But now… it was Nina, who had only recently stepped into the supernatural, who was showing an unbelievable openness of mind.

Of course Nina was not bound by traditional ways of thinking—for on the very first day this young lady touched the supernatural, what she saw was her Uncle Duncan stomping on a city-state and tearing the Sun in half. The highest level of supernatural corruption in this world had appeared to her as something being pinned down and given a solid beating.

In Nina’s eyes, Uncle Duncan was invincible. If anything caused trouble, she just had to let Uncle Duncan beat it up. Her train of thought was very clear and very simple.

“I need to confirm something,” Duncan suddenly said. Then he got up and left the dining hall.

He grabbed a big book and went straight to the captain’s cabin. With a loud “bang”, he dropped the book in front of Goathead.

Goathead jumped at the sudden noise: “C-captain?”

“What usually happens if you read books on the Boundless Sea?” Duncan asked bluntly.

Goathead paused, then answered on reflex: “Ah, that is obvious. Reading on the Boundless Sea usually draws the attention of certain wills from the world’s deep layers. For example, Intruders from the Spirit Realm, projections of demons from the Abyssal Deep, and even the whispers of Subspace may seize the chance to slip in during this process. They take

advantage of the reader's relaxed and unguarded mind to extend their projections into the Mortal Realm, and… What are you doing?"

Duncan had already spread open the big book he had brought from the city-state of Pland, a thick volume about the folk customs of many city-states. He flipped through its contents as he answered without looking up: "So when do those 'Intruders' you mentioned arrive?"

Goathead felt his thoughts starting to knot up, yet still answered on reflex even as they tangled: "U-usually, they should arrive as soon as the reading starts. Very quickly."

Duncan turned two more pages, then raised his head: "Then why aren't they here yet?"

Goathead: "…"

"Nina wants to do her winter homework on the ship," Duncan said to Goathead very seriously. "If you have a way to 'attract' those 'Intruders' you just mentioned, then draw them here. I have something to discuss with them."

"H-how do you plan to 'discuss' things with them?"

"By beating them up. Beating them up again and again until they promise not to disturb Nina's studying," Duncan said. Then he thought for a moment and carefully added: "Of course this is only my idea. I am not sure if it will work. You might be more of an expert in this area than I am."

Goathead's thoughts knotted up again. This time he hesitated even longer than before before he finally spoke: "I think… you may need to 'test' for a while longer."

Duncan: "…?"

“Normally, the Shadows drawn by reading all have the trait of chasing knowledge. That makes them just a little ‘smarter’ than ordinary Intruders,” Goathead’s words at last began to flow smoothly, though his tone was still strange. “Being smart means having some judgment. Even the chaotic Shadows of the Abyssal Deep and the Spirit Realm know how to seek benefit and avoid harm while chasing knowledge. They will not rashly show up in front of you…”

“I see,” Duncan nodded. His gaze moved over the lines of text in the book as he spoke casually. “So, any Intruder bold enough to come to the Vanished will not be some nobody or fool. It will be a powerful Intruder who has great confidence in itself and has weighed the risks carefully. That is actually good. It means I only need to beat one or two of them, and the strong ones will quickly understand the situation. I won’t have to worry about endless harassment from idiots.”

“I believe your reasoning makes perfect sense.”

Duncan did not respond to Goathead’s flattery. He just continued to sink into the book in front of him. He slowly turned the rough pages. His eyes wandered among the sometimes horrifying, sometimes mysterious folk customs of the southern city-states. His mind relaxed, little by little, and sank into the reading.

He waited quietly for the knowledge-chasing Intruders to smell this sweet bait and invade this seemingly unguarded Mortal Realm dimension.

But no Intruders appeared.

“It doesn’t seem to be working,” Duncan raised his head and spoke to Goathead, who was sitting quietly at the edge of the desk. “Do you have any other ideas?”

“Actually… I don’t think you need to cling to this. There are so many taboos on the Boundless Sea. Being unable to read is only…”

“Nina needs to do her winter homework,” Duncan said gently. “She cares about it.”

“You could let someone else do the reading, like Mr. Morris,” Goathead answered at once. “Followers of the God of Wisdom are better at controlling their minds. It is useful whether they are protecting themselves or setting a trap. Those Intruders most likely sensed your aura and did not dare show up. But if we set a trap, it should work.”

Duncan thought for a moment and felt that this was a good idea.

So he picked up the book and went straight back to the dining hall. Everyone was still there waiting. Nina and Shirley were whispering to each other, guessing what Duncan was doing. Alice and Dog were checking each other’s spelling words. Morris sat to the side with his eyes closed, resting. He opened them only when he heard Duncan walk in.

“I need a trap to draw in those invaders who chase knowledge,” Duncan walked straight to Morris and put the Folkways Treatise into the old scholar’s hands. “You read this book. Make your mind look like that of an unguarded scholar seeking knowledge. Lure a powerful malevolent spirit that chases knowledge onto the ship. I want to ‘talk’ with that Intruder, and also figure out what these Intruders really are.”

Morris jumped in shock. He had spent most of his life seeking knowledge on the academic road, and this was the first time he had heard such a crazy, wild idea. Yet the very next second, he saw from Duncan’s eyes that this ghost captain was completely serious.

And this really was the kind of plan only a Subspace shadow as powerful as him would dare to consider seriously.

After the first wave of shock, a strange excitement and sense of expectation rose up from the depths of the old scholar’s heart.

He had to admit that he himself suddenly felt a spark of curiosity.

If he read on purpose and lured a malevolent spirit under Captain Duncan’s watch, on the Vanished with its very special environment… what would happen?

Morris lifted the book in his hands.

Chapter 282: Hunters of Knowledge

The gently rolling waves softly beat against the outer wall of the cabin. From deep within the deck came faint creaks now and then. A lamp burning whale oil flickered quietly not far away. In its bright light, pairs of eyes, curious or expectant, shone.

Morris spread open the book on city-state folklore in front of him. Little by little, he relaxed his mind and lowered the defenses around his will. He let his thoughts open wide to knowledge and allowed the power in the pages to slowly flood his spirit.

He could feel that his unguarded mind was giving off an ever more tempting “scent” on this vast Boundless Sea.

A seeker of knowledge, a rash and unguarded seeker of knowledge, had opened his heart upon the sea. Those hungry Shadows roaming in the world’s deep layers had surely sensed this bait. Those restless, blind Shadows could not resist this lure, yet they still hesitated. Their minds, barely worthy of being called rational and only slightly enlightened by the pursuit of knowledge, felt an instinctive rejection toward the environment on the Vanished. That made them waver.

But they would not hesitate forever. Those things lurking in the Spirit Realm, the Abyssal Deep, and even Subspace did not possess true wisdom.

Morris slowly turned a page. His gaze drifted over the lines of text.

Folklore was what most attracted those Shadows. In folklore, Humans had gathered over long ages their fears, their awe, and their simple understanding of nature. It was roughly processed humanity, sweet emotions bound together with solidified knowledge. It was the perfect feast for hungry knowledge pursuers.

Another page turned. Fine dust between the sheets rose and drifted as they moved. The lamplight slanted through the curving paper, tracing leaping patterns of light and shadow in the narrow gaps between page and ink.

The cabin was very quiet.

The captain stood silently to one side, his gaze resting on the open book. The Sun fragment stood on the other side, watching the movements in the air.

Morris looked at the next line of text and saw the edges of the letters tremble slightly.

The Intruders were drawing near.

The invisible hunter of knowledge finally could not hold back anymore. It had come to the very edge of the Mortal Realm. Its tendrils sniffed at Morris’s mind through the pages, then began to disguise themselves as words. On what had been normal lines of text, strange symbols slowly emerged.

Those were letters that did not exist, describing knowledge that did not exist.

Skilled hunters often disguised themselves as prey. The pursuers of knowledge, when luring a Scholar, also liked to disguise themselves as “knowledge”. Reading them was the first step into the trap.

Morris watched as line after line of unreadable characters rose on the paper. He felt the power seeping out from them, trying to seduce him into reading.

He said softly: “It is here.”

In the next second, the “hunter” hidden in the pages and words suddenly seemed to sense something. A sharp, chaotic scream burst into everyone’s ears. At once the big book’s pages began to flip wildly. The black letters on the pages hopped as if they had lives of their own, struggling as they turned into splashes of ink, trying to tear themselves free from the yellowed paper.

Seeing this, Duncan showed a small smile.

His “fishing” had worked. When dealing with hunters of knowledge, using the Historian as bait had indeed done the job.

A plume of smoke surged out from the pages. The letters that had escaped the paper flowed quickly into the smoke. Howling, the smoke rushed out of the book and spun upward into a whirling cloud of dust. Within that dust, something black began to condense and take shape. In an instant it became a skeletal structure. A heap of chaotic, twisted black bone fragments clattered onto the floor beside the dining table, then in the blink of an eye pieced themselves together into something everyone present knew well:

An ugly, hound-shaped creature built from black bones.

Dog, who had been on full alert beside them, was stunned at the sight. He looked up at the others and said: “I don’t know that one.”

“If you don’t know it, that makes things easier,” Duncan said casually. He stepped toward the Abyssal Hound whose body had only just finished forming and still seemed confused. At that moment the creature finally reacted. It jerked its head up. Red light exploded in its hollow, blood-colored eye sockets. Endless black flames surged into the air from the cracks between its bones as it braced itself to fight back.

But its resistance ended before it even began. The instant black fire rose within the Abyssal Hound, its gaze met Duncan’s eyes. In the next second,

every tongue of flame burning inside it was dyed a ghostly green.

This Intruder from the depths of the Abyssal Deep lost control of its own flames in less than a second. It became a sacrificial victim under the captain's gaze. Its chaotic, broken mind probably never even had time to understand what was happening before it was swept up in roaring green spirit form fire. A shrill, mad howl shattered the calm aboard the Vanished. The cracking of flames consuming bone and strange tearing noises filled the dining hall.

A good hunter often appeared in the shape of prey – but a really lousy hunter truly did become prey.

What happened next was more than Dog could bear to watch. Dog's whole body shook into a trembling ball. He hid behind Shirley, hugged his head with his paws, and shivered. He watched the flickering firelight in front of him and listened to the sounds in the room. The red light in his eye sockets flickered on and off: "Ah… oh man, that burning… ah, those bones breaking… ah, that howling… ah, damn, I can't watch this…"

The dining hall grew quiet again.

A pile of shattered bone fragments lay scattered on the floor, with no details left to recognize. Thin blue-grey smoke curled above them. A few remaining green sparks jumped among the remains, devouring the last traces of power this Knowledge Hunter still had in the Mortal Realm.

Duncan frowned. The way things had unfolded was a bit unexpected, and the speed at which it ended was even more unexpected.

He walked forward and nudged the still slightly warm bones with the tip of his boot. Then he lifted his head and looked at Dog in the distance.

"Why was it a Abyssal Hound?"

“I… I don’t know…” Dog shivered at once. Even his voice shook. “I never read a book before, and I couldn’t read. Before I met Shirley I barely had any sense at all. I don’t know why one of my… hometown folks popped out.”

At this moment, Morris stood up. The Old Scholar’s steady voice finally came to Dog’s rescue: “In theory, the Malevolent Spirit drawn when you read a book is random. Most of the time it is an intangible Shadow from the Spirit Realm. But in a few cases, a Demon from the depths of the Abyssal Deep may come out instead. The ‘Abyssal Hound’ already has the meaning of ‘hunt’ and ‘chase’ in its name. In fact, they really are a kind of Knowledge Hunter, and a rather powerful type at that.”

“A rather powerful type?” Duncan raised his eyebrows when he heard this and glanced at Dog, who was still shivering at Shirley’s feet. “Really?”

“Under normal circumstances, if someone at sea is reading a book and a Abyssal Demon suddenly jumps out of it to attack, that person almost has no chance of survival,” Morris said, his expression a bit strange. “In the worse cases, a Abyssal Demon that invades the Mortal Realm by this route can quickly grow and enter a runaway state, then slaughter everyone on the ship in a short time. Not every ship is the Vanished.”

“All right,” Duncan said, nodding. He quickly adjusted the strength scale in his mind. His tone turned a bit odd. “If the strongest Intruders you can summon while reading are hunters like Dog, then it doesn’t seem that dangerous…”

As he spoke, he glanced at Nina: “Nina, you can do your winter homework on the ship from now on. If something really pops out, just beat it up yourself – just be careful not to burn anything.”

Nina laughed at once: “Okay!”

Then Duncan looked at Dog again: “By the way, you really didn’t know you are a ‘Hound that Chases Knowledge’?”

“I didn’t know,” Dog said, shaking his ugly big head. His voice was dull. “I already said, I used to drift around in a daze…”

Shirley frowned and thought for a long time. Suddenly she blurted out: “If that’s how it is, and Abyssal Hounds can’t read just like Dog, then why do they chase knowledge?”

“Alice studies cooking too,” Duncan said offhandedly. “Maybe it’s just a hobby.”

Shirley nodded as if she half understood, then lowered her head to look at her partner. Dog had quietly crawled under the nearby table. He hugged his huge head with his paws and spoke in a muffled voice: “Don’t ask me, I don’t know anything… this place is just too damn scary…”

Duncan could not help shaking his head with a smile. He suddenly felt that after so many people had come aboard, the mood on the ship really was getting better day by day. They already had these pleasant everyday moments. He truly did not know how lively things would become once Vanna came aboard.

With that cheerful feeling and a bit of hope for the future, he stepped forward and kicked the pile of black bones on the floor that were gradually cooling.

This was just a heartless Abyssal Demon. It was nothing like Dog.

“Alice, clean up this pile.”

…

Under the bright, warm sunlight, Vanna, who was walking through the Cathedral courtyard, suddenly felt a chill. She shivered without thinking.

She lifted her head and looked at the little path in the courtyard under the sunlight. After a long moment she let out a deep sigh.

[What has to come will always come.]

Chapter 283: Official Paperwork

Every day before noon, Vanna walked across the courtyard of the great Cathedral in Pland. She followed the little path between the flowerbeds to the sanctuary. The path was one hundred and three steps long. From the sanctuary entrance to the statue of the Goddess took another twenty-seven steps. Ever since she had become this city's Inquisitor, these step counts had become part of her life.

She knew everything inside this Cathedral. She knew every floor tile from the courtyard to the sanctuary as well as she knew her own hands.

In all the days and nights that had passed, she had never imagined that this short stretch of road could feel so hard and so long.

The sanctuary doors opened, and the too-bright sunlight was left behind her. After her eyes adjusted to the dimmer interior, Vanna saw two figures standing before the statue of the Goddess in the center of the room.

Light from the high stained glass windows shone down and spread a soft glow over the statue of the Goddess. Archbishop Valentine and Pope Helena turned their eyes at the same time. In the sunlight, their gaze fell upon the Inquisitor who was walking into the room.

"You are here," Helena said with a small nod. "One minute later than we agreed."

"Sorry," Vanna said as she stepped forward. She bowed her head slightly beneath the statue of the Goddess, then looked at the Pope. "Handing my work over to my subordinates delayed me a few minutes."

“Never mind,” Helena nodded lightly, then glanced at Valentine. “I have already spoken with Bishop Valentine about your situation. He will help you with the handover and arrangements for your duties. You do not need to worry about the city-state. Your uncle has also received the news. He understands the Church’s decision, but I still hope you will talk with him later and ease some of his worries about the future.”

Even though she believed she had made plenty of mental preparations, Vanna’s heart still gave a little jump when she heard the Pope’s words.

A feeling rose within her, something between dream and Mortal Realm, leaving her dazed for a moment. She tried to grasp that feeling clearly and finally found that all of her emotions were summed up in a single sigh: ah, it really happened.

But then she felt confused again, and even a bit absurd. She looked at the Pope in front of her and could not help saying: “You really are going to send me onto the Vanished – of course, I am not doubting your decision, I just suddenly feel that… this is not a matter to treat lightly. At the very least, we should understand Captain Duncan’s attitude. Would he really allow a high-ranking priest to board that ship so casually?”

Vanna felt her wording was a little messy, but she forced herself to sort out her thoughts and went on: “Yesterday it all happened so suddenly. Only after I went back did it strike me that something was off. The Vanished is not some ‘open zone’ that one can just enter at will. How do you plan to…”

“Ah, you finally thought of this question,” Helena said with a smile, shaking her head. “I thought you would only remember to ‘ask for directions’ when it was time to depart.”

Vanna’s eyes widened in surprise. Then she saw Helena take out a rolled parchment sheet from beside her and hand it over with a bright, amused smile.

Puzzled, Vanna accepted the roll and carefully opened it. Her gaze swept over the words written on it, and her expression grew more and more interesting.

“To the servants of Goddess Gamona of the Deep Sea Church… We hereby accept the transfer of one member of your staff required for duty, to be temporarily assigned to a combat post aboard this vessel… In-post treatment will be equal to that of a first-class crew member. The wages and all related expenses for this person will continue to be borne by your institution, to be paid in the following manner…

Captain of the Vanished, Duncan Abnomar, signed at Visions–Pland, December 19th, 1900.”

Besides the handwritten signature at the end, there was also a striking red seal.

Vanna: “…”

The young Inquisitor looked a little stunned. She lowered her head to look at the Personnel Transfer Acceptance Letter in her hands, then raised her eyes to the Pope in front of her. After glancing back and forth several times, her gaze fell on Bishop Valentine.

“Don’t look at me,” Valentine said with a blank face. “I didn’t expect this either.”

Vanna felt her lips tremble: “The signature on this…”

“It’s real,” Helena said calmly. “The seal is real as well. If you go to the City-State Archive and search, you can even find records from a century ago, when the Vanished came to resupply at Pland Harbor. They bear the same seal and the same signature.”

Vanna listened in a daze. She opened her mouth, as if she still had a whole bellyful of words she wanted to say, but Helena spoke first and cut her off:

“You have to admit, this is very reasonable.”

“I…” Vanna raised a hand and pointed at herself, then lifted the parchment sheet in her hand. After a long pause, she finally squeezed out a sentence: “But isn’t this a bit too reasonable?! And when did you…”

“Just yesterday,” Helena said in all seriousness, though a trace of joy hid in her eyes. “Captain Duncan and I discussed your onboarding process in detail. We have always felt this should be a formal, contract-bound personnel transfer. For that, we needed proper paperwork to file.”

The female Pope paused there. Seeing the tangled expression still on Vanna’s face, she spread her hands with a smile: “What else did you expect, Vanna? How else were we supposed to send you to the Vanished? Pile up some bonfires, draw blasphemous symbols all over the floor, then tie you to a stake and send you over as a sacrificial rite? Like certain dark heretics who tie up maidens in damp caves and offer them by sacrificial rite to Subspace?

“Vanna, we are the orthodox Church. We follow proper procedure.”

Vanna’s mouth twitched. She realized that at the start she truly had not thought at all about the details of this “handover”. Now that Helena reminded her, she could see how reasonable the document in front of her was. Yet because the process was so reasonable, the whole thing felt even more uncanny.

All of her anxious guesses about the future were shattered in that instant. She even started to suspect that on the Vanished she would see a rich staff meal, and after the formal dinner there might even be a barbecue on the deck…

This was the Vanished, after all. The Lost Home.

Every bit of that strangeness in Vanna’s eyes was clear to Helena.

“All right. Now that you have seen the document, I trust you have let go of your last bit of worry,” the Pope said with a smile. “Go and rest now, and make some preparations before you set out. There are more detailed notes on the back of the document, including the exact time and method of handover. You can read them when you go back.”

And just like that, Vanna was sent out of the sanctuary in a daze.

After the young Inquisitor left, the sanctuary became quiet. After two full minutes, Valentine finally broke the silence: “In fact, I’m very curious.”

Helena turned slightly: “Curious about what?”

“What exactly has happened that made you suddenly decide to send Vanna onto the Vanished?” Valentine asked, his expression a little serious. “I understand the reasons you gave. They do hold up. But the whole thing still feels… a little rushed to me. You seem eager to establish contact with that ‘Captain Duncan’, and you did not make enough preparations beforehand. What happened?”

“You are a perceptive man, Valentine. You always have been,” Helena said quietly. She looked at the old Bishop who had been loyal to the Church for so many years, then sighed. “This matter will not remain a secret for long. Telling you now will not change anything.”

She paused for a moment, then spoke slowly: “Do you remember the ‘warning’ that Captain Duncan sent not long ago through Vanna?”

“‘Warning?’” Valentine frowned slightly, then quickly thought of something. “You mean the one about Visions 001…”

“The Elven city-state of Lightwind Harbor near the border has recently sent disturbing news,” Helena said with a nod. “The ‘Sea Witch’ Lucretia delivered a gift to them. Can you guess what it was?”

Valentine froze. Thinking of the details hinted at in the Pope's words, he faintly realized the truth. His expression changed at once: "Don't tell me… something really fell from the sky?"

"A fragment of a glowing glowing orb that fell from above," Helena said. "It is pale gold, a geometric body even larger than the Storm Cathedral. We do not yet have solid proof that it is a piece that broke off Visions 001, but…"

Helena did not go on. She only shook her head.

Valentine listened in stunned silence. After a long time, he finally squeezed a few syllables out of his throat: "…Goddess above."

"Our world is going wrong, and things are worse than we imagined. The Vanished is so far the only voice that has given the civilized world a warning – and that warning has now been confirmed," Helena said slowly. "This is Captain Duncan actively showing goodwill. No matter how terrifying that ship once was, we must give a reply now. After all… what is about to fall is not just one city-state, but the Sun above our heads."

"…Can Vanna really carry out this task?" Valentine had set aside his earlier doubts, only to pick up a new worry. "She is actually a somewhat rash person and not very good at… careful, delicate human dealings. If we are sending an envoy 'aboard', she is not the best choice."

"We are not the ones who pick the best candidate, Valentine," Helena said, shaking her head.

She turned around and quietly fixed her gaze on the holy image of the storm Goddess Gamona.

"The ones who play the game decided the pieces' places from the very beginning."

Chapter 284: The Day of Boarding

In the Upper City, near the Cathedral, there was a high platform. It had once been part of the city park, but after the steam core reconstruction project, the original park facilities were moved elsewhere. Only this lonely platform remained here, like a forgotten knight standing on high, watching over the factories and plaza below.

From the platform, one could overlook the entire Cathedral District and the central factory district.

In her rare free time, Vanna came here to relax. When her thoughts would not calm, Vanna also came here to think quietly and sort out her mood.

The afternoon sunlight was good. Even with a light breeze, the platform was not very cold. The gentle sea wind swept across the platform, lifting the hair beside her ear and making it itch a little.

Vanna tossed her long white hair back. She let her gaze rest on the winding, fog-shrouded steam pipes in the distance. After a long time, she finally broke the silence: “I am going away for a while.”

“Going away?” Heidi turned her head in surprise. “Where are you going?”

“I am not sure. It might be somewhere very far away, and I may be gone for a long time.” Vanna looked into Heidi’s eyes. “I cannot reveal the exact route, but I should at least tell you before I leave.”

Heidi blinked, looking a little confused: “But you are the city-state’s Inquisitor. Can an Inquisitor just go off on a long journey like that?”

“I…” Vanna opened her mouth and tried to make her expression look like a smile. “It is an arrangement from the Church. A direct transfer order from the Storm Cathedral.”

“Ah… so that is how it is.” Heidi nodded in sudden understanding. She did not really understand the inner rules of the Deep Sea Church, but once the name ‘Storm Cathedral’ was brought up, there was no need to explain much. “So this is a holy mission, then? Are you being sent outside the diocese to fight Heretics?”

Vanna’s expression seemed to stiffen for a moment: “…In a sense, it does have something to do with Heretics, but it is not a combat mission.”

Heidi did not notice the subtle change in her friend’s tone. She only suddenly sighed: “Sigh, my father also went off on a long trip recently. There was no prophetic omen beforehand. He just suddenly told me he had to go deal with something, and my mother would not let me ask much. Now you are leaving too. It feels like you are all being mysterious.”

“Mr. Morris also went out?” Vanna muttered without thinking, but soon she shook her head, a faintly self-mocking look on her face. “He is probably off visiting his friends in the academic world, or attending some event. A scholar like him gets invitations from universities in various city-states all the time… Anyway, it is not the same place I am going.”

Heidi turned her head, looking at her friend with some doubt: “Why do I feel you are acting strange? You look weighed down. Are you uneasy because you are going far away? You really have not left the city-state much.”

“That is not it. I am probably just nervous because I was suddenly assigned to a task I have never dealt with before,” Vanna said, shaking her head. “You do not have to worry about me.”

“All right then.” Heidi let out a breath. Then, as if she suddenly remembered something, she suggested excitedly: “Right, how about we go to the cinema together? There is a new show out. We can use it to change your mood. You should really get in touch with more of what is popular these days. It might even help you expand your social circle…”

Vanna completely ignored the last two sentences. She only raised her eyebrows with some curiosity: “A new show? What is it about?”

“It is a work by Master Director Sandok, called ‘Borderland Terror’. It is about a small frontier village that falls into Heretic worship. They offer the village’s women as a sacrificial rite to a ‘cave evil spirit’, and in the end, brave guardians wipe out the evil. They say this show even uses a new technology called a ‘sound track’. While the images play, synchronized sound comes out of machines on both sides of the screen…”

Heidi eagerly introduced these ‘trendy new elements’ to her friend, but she noticed that Vanna’s expression grew stranger and stranger. Halfway through, Heidi hesitated and stopped. Then she thought for a moment and waved her hand: “All right, maybe you do not like that one. There is another show, called ‘Nightwatch’. It is about brave guardians entering a secret realm, getting trapped in a Heretic nest, and being forced to rely on their own wisdom and experience to survive inside while trying to hold on to their true selves… You do not like that one either?”

Heidi scratched her hair, rummaging through her memory: “Then I will recommend a book instead. It is a popular novel lately, called ‘Walking with Shadows’. It is about…”

Vanna finally could not listen anymore. Her face was almost turning dark as she cut off her friend’s chatter: “Thank you, but that is really not necessary.”

Then she seemed to realize her tone was a bit harsh. She sighed slightly, rubbing her forehead with her fingers as she explained quietly: “Thank you for caring. But the mission I am about to carry out requires firm will and a clear mind. Before I set out, it is better not to touch too many things that might disturb the heart.”

“Ah, all right. I did not think that through,” Heidi said with an awkward laugh. “I forgot you are a ‘professional’.”

Vanna waved her hand.

After a while, she heard Heidi’s voice again: “My break is almost over. I still have two patients with appointments this afternoon.”

Vanna let out a light breath: “Go back to work. I should start getting ready for my departure too.”

Heidi answered with a soft sound, but before she left the platform she suddenly stopped again. Heidi turned back. In the afternoon sunlight and the breeze, her expression looked a little hesitant: “When you leave… can I see you off?”

“…No. This is a special mission.”

“Then will you write letters back?”

Vanna hesitated for a moment.

She looked at Heidi. The wind blew her white hair, and in the fluttering strands, it felt as if a drifting Veil had already fallen between her and her friend.

“…I do not know,” Vanna said quietly. “But I will… try. Maybe it will not be that strict where I am going.”

“All right, then I will wait for your letters.” Heidi’s face suddenly bloomed with a bright smile. She stepped forward, pulled a crystal pendant from

inside her collar, and shook it in the air. Then she pointed at Vanna's chest. "Matching amulets. You will have good luck."

Her friend left.

On the wind-swept platform, only Vanna remained.

The young Inquisitor lowered her head and looked at the small pendant on her chest.

"…Good luck, huh," she muttered softly, her expression turning a little strange. "I hope that antique shopkeeper's goods really can bring some good luck."

A loud peal of bells suddenly rang from the direction of the Cathedral, cutting off Vanna's thoughts.

She looked up toward the source of the sound and saw the huge clock face on the Great Bell tower showing the time. The light of the Sun had already passed the highest point in the sky and was slowly moving toward the west side of the great Cathedral.

She took out the parchment sheet and looked at the words on the back. That was her Induction Brief.

According to the instructions on the Induction Brief, a Messenger would come to pick her up in one hour. Before that, she should go to wait in the central courtyard of the great Cathedral. No unrelated people would disturb the handover.

What kind of Messenger would it be? And how would she be sent onto the Vanished, far away on the Boundless Sea?

Vanna had many questions in her heart, but she still set off toward the great Cathedral.

She had had many plans. Before leaving the city-state where she was born and raised, she had wanted to stroll through her favorite shops, visit the theater once more, go to the Harbor, see a few more friends, and go to the sanctuary for one more prayer…

But there was not enough time. She did not have that much freedom.

In the central courtyard of the great Cathedral, Pope Helena and Archbishop Valentine had already been waiting for her for some time.

“The Messenger has not arrived yet,” Valentine said with a nod to Vanna as she walked into the courtyard. “Are you ready?”

Vanna looked at what she carried.

Besides the greatsword that never left her side, she had only a packed suitcase. She did not own many personal things. Aside from the necessary changes of clothes, the heaviest items in the suitcase were her prayer book and a few Church texts that had received divine blessing.

Those were things she could safely read on the Boundless Sea, and they might help ease the boredom of life on the ship.

“Everything is here,” Vanna said with a nod. Then she looked up at the silent Pope beside her. “I can still pray on the ship, right?”

“Of course,” Helena answered with a smile. “Captain Duncan even promised that you can turn an extra cabin into a small chapel.”

“…Then I will at least have something to look forward to in my ‘crew member life’,” Vanna sighed. “I can hardly imagine what that life will be like.”

Helena opened her mouth, as if she wanted to say something, but just then the sound of crackling flames and beating wings suddenly came from the sky, cutting off the conversation in the courtyard.

The Messenger had arrived.

Vanna looked up in surprise, but she only had time to see a mass of emerald flame falling from the sky like a meteor. A pair of huge bone wings snapped open inside the fire. In the next second, the flames ‘fell’ onto the path in the courtyard and turned into a whirling, rising doorway.

“It is time to go,” Pope Helena said beside her, with both a reminder and a gentle urge.

“Mm.” Vanna gave a small nod. At that moment, she cast aside the last bit of hesitation in her heart and stepped forward.

She took a deep breath and crossed the spinning gate of flame. Her thoughts boiled over in that instant.

What kind of scene would lie beyond the door? What kind of life was waiting for her on that ship? Would she first see that terrifying ghost captain, or some… sailor on the Vanished?

What kind of strange forms would the crew members on that ship have?

The flames roared up and then vanished just as suddenly. Crossing the doorway took only a moment.

Vanna only felt a brief daze, and then damp, cold sea wind blew against her face. The sound of crashing waves came to her ears.

She blinked and patted her forehead hard.

Vanna felt that the teleportation might have gone a little wrong.

Or maybe there was something wrong with her eyes.

Because she saw… Morris standing right in front of her, smiling at her.

Chapter 285: Welcoming the Newcomer

To Vanna, everything that had happened over the past two days seemed to be covered by a filter of unreality. Her life had been turned upside down, so much that it felt like an absurd dream. She often wondered if she had already fallen into an illusion without knowing it—and in this moment, her doubt about herself reached its peak.

She actually saw Mr. Morris standing in front of her, with a smile on his face.

The young Inquisitor squeezed her eyes shut and knocked hard on her forehead. When she opened her eyes again, Morris was still there—and now there was also a tall figure beside the old mister.

It was that gloomy, dignified ghost captain.

“Welcome aboard, Vanna,” Morris said. “I know you have many questions…”

Vanna opened her mouth, but before she could speak, there was a sudden bang beside her. She did not feel any threat in that sound, but it still startled her. She turned her head on reflex and saw a big burst of colorful paper scraps and ribbons flying toward her.

A beautiful lady with silver-white hair down to her waist was staring blankly in this direction. Smoke from spent gunpowder still rose faintly from the tube in her hand.

Vanna: “…?”

Before she could react, the silver-haired lady happily grabbed a second paper tube from the side. She fiddled with it in front of Vanna, lifted it, and pulled the little string on it.

Seeing this, Vanna quickly tried to warn her: “Ah! You are holding it the wrong way…”

Her warning came too late.

The small charge inside the tube exploded with a bang. The silver-haired woman was hit full in the face by the ribbons and confetti that sprayed out. She instinctively threw her head back. Then there was a strange popping sound, and a head rolled down onto the deck under Vanna’s gaze.

Vanna’s eyes went wide. Even with her mental discipline, she almost jumped on the spot. Right after that, she heard a cry from behind her: “Ah! Uncle Duncan! Alice’s head fell off again!”

In the next second, a girl who looked about high-school age rushed over from the side, scrambling after the head that was rolling around on the deck. Another girl came running from another direction, holding the leash of a huge black dog. She joined the chase and shouted: “I told you earlier it was a bad idea to let her hold it!”

“You were too scared to hold it yourself!”

“Even so, we cannot just let Alice handle it alone… Ah, her head rolled down the stairs!”

“A hook, where is a hook… A stick works too…”

“I found a rope! Throw it down, throw it down… Miss Alice, bite it yourself, I will pull you up!”

The deck turned noisy in an instant. The two girls rushed up and down after the rolling head, while the headless silver-haired woman stumbled around in place, completely at a loss.

Mr. Morris, who had been speaking a moment earlier, now pressed a hand to his forehead and sighed nonstop. The air still held the odd smell left by the spent confetti tubes.

Vanna was in a rare state of utter confusion. She stared at the chaos on the deck, strands of colorful paper hanging from her hair and shoulders. She felt she sort of understood what had just happened, but also felt it might be better not to understand at all.

It was a welcome ritual—under any other circumstances, it would have been quite a happy sight.

“You see? I told you I have a very troublesome group of crew members,” the gloomy, dignified Captain Duncan finally spoke. His voice pulled Vanna out of her daze at last. “This ship is always this noisy. But from another angle, your life here should not be boring.”

Vanna’s face stayed blank. Deep inside, her thoughts were roaring like a thousand explosions, but she truly had no idea what expression she should be wearing.

She looked up at the scene on the deck. Nina and Shirley had already ‘fished’ the head out from between the stairs and were clumsily putting it back where it belonged. A fat pigeon had flown in from somewhere and was flapping nearby, loudly shouting something strange like “Little hammer forty, little hammer forty.”

She finally got a clear look at the silver-haired woman’s face and remembered where she had seen it before.

It had been in the antique shop in the Lower City.

Back then, the woman had golden hair. Now that Vanna thought about it, that must have been a disguise.

She looked at Shirley, then at Nina, then at Mr. Morris, who stood nearby with a helpless look and his hands spread. Vanna finally understood everything.

The entire world had already changed in secret, and she was only now finding out.

“How many more ‘secrets’ are there?” Vanna’s mouth twitched at last, and she regained the ability to speak. This respected scholar had been a senior she had known since childhood. Him appearing on this ghost ship was the most unbelievable thing she had seen today. But right now, this senior was also the only person she could think to question. “How long have you been…?”

“Actually, not for very long—only a little earlier than you,” Morris answered with a gentle smile and a light nod. “Heidi does not know about this.”

“Ah, she really looks like she does not know. She was still complaining to me today, saying you suddenly went out to deal with something without explaining anything,” Vanna said in a complicated tone. “Who would have thought… that you would just appear in front of me like this, on the ‘Vanished’.”

“It seems I did leave in a bit of a hurry,” Morris said with a nod. “I should bring her some local specialties from the north as a gift later.”

Vanna pressed her lips together, then turned to look at the master of the ship.

“What other ‘surprises’ are coming?” she asked helplessly. Everything that had happened after she stepped through that gate of flame had shattered all

the mental preparation she had been doing since morning. She had never felt this lost and flustered in her life. “Tell me in advance so I can at least be ready for it.”

Before Duncan could answer, Nina already ran over, speaking to Vanna with great excitement: “We are having a banquet tonight! A welcome party for the new crew member!”

“There will be really tasty fish soup!” Shirley shouted from the side. “Fish caught personally by the captain.”

“And then a deck barbecue!” Nina quickly added. “There will be fish, beef, and wheat juice!”

“No alcohol,” Duncan’s voice came from right behind Nina at once. “Not even if you call it ‘wheat juice’.”

Nina’s face drooped at once: “…Not even a little?”

“The sweet fruit wine from last time was already the limit,” Duncan said with a straight face. “Beer is still too early for you.”

“Oh.”

Vanna looked at Nina, then at Duncan. Only after a long moment did she sigh softly: “So that antique shop really had problems—and I did not notice anything.”

“We have always operated legally. The goods are not genuine, but the prices are fair,” Duncan said with a faint, amused look. “As for you not noticing anything… actually, that is a good thing. You know what I mean.”

“Yes. Her Eminence the Pope reminded me to rein in my urge to pry when I am near you,” Vanna sighed again and looked at the ugly, skeletal giant dog beside Shirley. “If I am not mistaken, this is a Abyssal Hound, isn’t it? And

this little girl is a Summoner who formed a symbiotic pact with Abyssal demons?”

Dog shook his head eagerly: “Ah, yes, yes, yes.”

Vanna jumped in surprise: “…This demon can talk?!”

“It can not only talk, it can now even spell its own name and do addition and subtraction within one hundred,” Duncan said casually. “Among the crew members of the Vanished, it is considered fairly well educated.”

Vanna stared for a moment, then looked at Alice, who was a short distance away, rolling her neck. She had already noticed the details of Alice’s joints earlier, and now she spoke thoughtfully: “A doll… so that means…”

“Anomaly 099. Its former name was ‘Doll spirit coffin’. Now you people seem to just call her ‘doll’, but she has her own real name, which you should already know. Here, you can just call her Alice,” Duncan said calmly. Then he added, “Do not worry. She is very safe now.”

“Hello!” Alice waved and smiled, her face full of harmless cheer. “I did not scare you just now, did I?”

Vanna reached up and touched her own neck on reflex. Then she managed a slightly stiff smile in return, counting it as an answer to this cursed Doll’s greeting.

Just then, Shirley ran to a wooden barrel nearby and pulled out another paper tube with bright, colorful wrapping. She held it up happily and ran back: “Alice! Alice! There is one more here! Do you want to…”

“Stop playing with those things!” Duncan glared at Shirley. “So who bought them? And why are they not on the purchase list?”

“I…” Nina shrank her neck at once and spoke carefully. “I used my own pocket money to buy them.”

Duncan was silent for a moment, then turned to look at Alice: “Next time they give you some strange thing to play with, come tell me first.”

Alice nodded while picking colorful scraps of paper out of her hair: “Oh.”

Vanna let out another long, deep sigh.

She went over to Morris and lowered her voice: “It is… always like this here?”

“From what I have seen, always,” Morris replied just as quietly. “Sometimes it is even livelier—especially when Miss Alice has some new ideas.”

Vanna: “…”

Chapter 286: transformation

“This will be your room from now on. All the basic daily necessities are here. If you need anything else, you can tell Alice. She will help arrange it for you, as long as she doesn’t forget.

“The room next door is a small storeroom. You can use it freely. It’s fine for prayer or meditation. You are a devout believer, so you should need something like that.

“Do not go to the lower decks. Do not get curious about the locked cabins. Sometimes strange creaks or the sound of ropes rubbing on the floor will come from deep inside this ship. You don’t need to make a fuss. Just leave it alone. If something is really wrong, I will handle it myself.

“When you live on this ship, remember the crew code.

“Do you have anything else you want to ask?”

Vanna stood at the door of the room assigned to her. She looked at the plain and normal furniture in the cabin and still felt a little dazed.

An ordinary bed, an ordinary table and chairs, an ordinary cabinet. Everything was very clean. She saw no suspicious shadows, no bloodstains hidden in the corners, and no blasphemous symbols written on the ceiling or floor. If she did not think about the fact that this place was inside the Vanished, then this was simply a very ordinary cabin.

But if she had to say it, there really were some unusual things here.

There was a special “crew code” on this ship. There was a forbidden “secret place” deep in the cabins. The whole ship was alive. Even the ropes and buckets on deck sometimes made unsettling sounds. These strange details more or less matched her imagination of the Vanished.

But compared to everything she had imagined, these bits of eeriness already seemed gentle and harmless.

“…I remember everything,” Vanna nodded slowly and said to Duncan, who had personally brought her to the room. “For now I don’t have any more questions.”

“Good,” Duncan said calmly. “Put your luggage away. Dinner is about to start. You can skip the barbecue on deck after dinner if you are not interested. That is just Shirley and Nina fooling around. But you must attend dinner. That is the necessary step for a new member joining the crew.”

“Yes.”

Vanna quietly put away her luggage. After a short hesitation, she also left her heavy two?handed sword in the room for now.

No matter what, walking into the dining room with a two?handed greatsword would be far too strange.

She followed Duncan toward the dining room and stayed silent the whole way.

But her heavy, worried look did not escape Duncan’s eyes.

“If you want to ask something, you can ask at any time,” Duncan slowed his steps and turned his head slightly to look at Vanna beside him. “There are actually not many strict rules on this ship. On a long ocean voyage, the worst thing is a crew member hiding things in their heart. The unease and

confusion in your heart will be magnified by the Boundless Sea. You never know when they might turn into an uninvited guest.”

Vanna’s heart tightened. She hesitated for a moment and finally spoke: “It’s actually nothing. It’s just that things developed differently from what I imagined. Right now I feel a bit… at a loss.”

“Oh, that is understandable. I can even roughly guess what kind of image of the Vanished you had before,” Duncan said casually. “Having the first day be a lively welcome party instead of a dark, bloody sacrificial ritual feels quite unbelievable, doesn’t it?”

“It’s not as exaggerated as a sacrificial ritual… but the scene I first imagined really wasn’t as peaceful as this.” Vanna seemed to smile a little. In any case, she was a bit more relaxed now.

“That is one of the reasons your Pope sent you onto this ship,” Duncan said slowly. “She needs to know what the real Vanished is like. And I… also need you as a bridge to rebuild contact with the civilized world.”

They reached the dining room.

Under the swaying whale oil lamp, the long table was already covered with dishes. A large tureen of steaming fish soup sat at the most eye?catching spot on the table. The crew stood on both sides of the long table, waiting for their captain. From somewhere deep in the ship came a low, gentle creaking sound, as if this ancient exploration vessel were humming a song as the veil of night fell.

Vanna took her seat at the empty place prepared for her and looked at the food before her, sending waves of fragrance into the air under the warm light.

Alice stood up, filled a bowl with hot soup, and placed it in front of the new crew member.

“Please drink,” the doll girl said politely.

Vanna looked at the bowl in front of her. From her earlier talk with Morris, she already knew the “truth” of this special food and the unique symbolic meaning of this dinner. Now, looking at the pieces of fish swaying slightly in the thick soup, she felt her vision blur for a second, but the blur faded at once.

“Is this my fate?” she could not help muttering.

“No,” Alice shook her head, her face full of simple seriousness. “This is your fish soup.”

Vanna was left speechless, then a smile slowly appeared at the corners of her mouth.

It smelled pretty good.

…

In the great Cathedral of the city?state of Pland, Helena stood quietly in front of the holy statue of the storm Goddess and gazed at the candles burning at the statue’s feet.

The candleholders, covered in complex and delicate patterns, burned quietly. But in Helena’s sight, the flames at their tops slowly rose, then shook, split, spread, and flowed outward.

In the blink of an eye, the hall vanished. The statue vanished. The candleholders vanished. In Helena’s vision, only countless flames remained. Big or small, near or far, high or low, the candles filled the space around her, leaping and burning in a dark, chaotic, boundless void like stars.

Each little flame represented a Saint. They represented the strength the Deep Sea Church had relied on from its peak until now.

Helena raised her head, and the countless flames in her vision moved quickly with her. Many flames drifted far away. Only one bright flame came to her, burning quietly in the darkness.

The Pope gazed at this flame and waited patiently.

In her sight, the flame finally began to tremble. The shaking grew stronger and stronger. Then, in one instant, it suddenly burned fiercely. The flame shot up several times higher, and a pale green light burst out within the fire.

The whole process lasted only two or three seconds.

The flame then calmed down again. It gave off a faint green glow and burned in the darkness, bright and silent.

“…She really completed the transformation,” Helena could not help murmuring softly. She raised her hand without thinking, as if she wanted to touch that quietly burning flame with her fingertip.

But she stopped at the last step.

The countless candle flames in the darkness faded at once. The scene of the cathedral returned to normal.

Helena looked up at the veiled statue of the Goddess that quietly looked down over the hall.

Faint light and shadow flowed across the surface of the statue. The hard stone shell, carved from rock, seemed to gain the softness of living flesh. From under the thick veil, a pale, unreal breath slowly seeped out.

The statue lowered its head. Semi?transparent, spirit?like tendrils gathered out of that pale mist and slid out from the edges of the veil, hanging slowly down in front of Helena.

The tendrils curled and pulsed, waiting for Helena to speak.

“Your messenger has already boarded the ship and was completely transformed two minutes ago. Now she is a part of the Vanished,” Helena said calmly and respectfully as she looked at the tendrils. “But as before, she has still kept her humanity and sanity, and she still maintains her psychic link with the believers.”

The tendrils swayed slightly and gave off a low, strange rustling sound, mixed with the soft sound of waves.

“Yes, I will watch her condition often,” Helena said. “But if her mind really does have problems… for example, if she shows signs of corruption from Subspace, then…”

Two of the ghostly tendrils moved more strongly. In the strange rustling sound, there were strings of mutters no human could make or understand.

“I understand,” Helena let out a soft breath and lowered her head. “I will do my best to pull her back. If things truly cannot be saved, I will also try to let her return to your kingdom with as much of her humanity kept as possible.”

The tendrils swayed gently, whispering in a soothing tone. Then these ghostly limbs turned once more into pale, thin mist and slowly rose into the air.

The mist returned under the veil of the Goddess, and the statue shifted a little and went back to its former pose, calmly looking down at the mortal world.

…

The veil of night hung low. The cold radiance of the World’s Wound already shone high in the night sky.

Pack ice covered the sea. Among the rippling waves, sharp, treacherous edges of ice lurked. The towering bow of an ironclad warship cut through

the waves on its night voyage, moving proudly through the endless sea of floating ice.

Large and small chunks of ice seemed to fear the might of the ironclad warship. Before the Sea Mist came near, they had already moved aside. Under the cold light of the World's Wound, a narrow path seemed to open on the sea, and the steel giant moved forward along this path.

Tyrian stood at the bow, staring at the dark, icy sea ahead, his brow deeply furrowed.

"We have already entered the Frost Sea, Captain," the voice of First Mate Aiden came through the night wind. "Around this time tomorrow, we should be back at the home port."

Tyrian did not look back. "Any new news from Frostholm?"

"The spies report that the authority in Frostholm has moved that submersible to Dagger Island near the city?state. There is an old ocean observatory there, and it is now being used as the research site for the 'eighth Number Three submersible,'" Aiden answered. "It seems they still haven't opened the submersible's hatch. Maybe they are being careful, or maybe they are waiting for higher?level orders."

"All right. At least those useless people still have the most basic level of caution," Tyrian let out a quiet breath, but his brow did not relax at all. "Aside from that, any new information?"

"The city of Frostholm is still calm for now. The authority seems to have sealed the news about the submersible. But whether they seal it or not doesn't matter much. Almost no one today knows about the Abyssal Trench Project from half a century ago," Aiden said, shaking his head. "Compared to that, there is another matter that looks unrelated to the submersible, but seems worth attention."

“Another matter?”

“Yes. It’s about… rumors that the dead are returning.”

Chapter 287: Frostholm, Death, and Night Sailing

Frostholm was a very cold place. For eighty percent of the year, this city?state was bathed in the restless, never?ending cold winds of the Frost Sea. Cold air blew constantly from the frozen seas further north, howling past Frostholm’s high city walls and steep seaside cliffs. This chill made many people shy away.

Yet Frostholm was also the largest city?state in the whole Frost Sea. In spite of the cold, the center of this great island held the richest boiling gold mines in the northern region. Boiling gold was the most crucial raw material for the key parts of steam cores. It could even be seen as the industrial foundation of this age. The industrial system built around the boiling gold mines kept this northern city?state running and brought it endless wealth and prosperity.

And death.

At Frostholm, on the edge of the mining district near the city cemetery’s gate, a completely black steam car still idled. Under the bright gas street lamps, several corpse?bearers in thick black robes were lifting a coffin out of the car together. Another tall, thin figure in a black robe stood by the car. This person’s entire face was hidden in the shadows of a wide?brimmed hat. In the crossing shadows, one could see layer after layer of bandages.

A few steps away, a shriveled old man stood by the cemetery gate. His body was slightly hunched, and his whole figure seemed wrapped in heavy

shadow. He watched the busy corpse?bearers with a cold expression.

The corpse?bearers from the Church of Death were especially silent. They did not make a sound while moving the coffin. Only a faint bumping noise sounded now and then, making the already gloomy graveyard seem even more eerie and dead.

After an unknown time, the grim old warden of the cemetery finally spoke and broke the silence: “Cause of death?”

“She slipped and fell into a machine shaft,” the tall, thin, bandaged figure answered. The voice was a slightly hoarse female voice that still sounded quite young. “She died on the spot and has already received baptism. The detailed situation is in the transfer documents. You can read them yourself.”

“How long will she stay?” The old man’s expression and tone did not change at all. It was as if he were talking about a stone that was about to be carried into his room.

The bandaged figure looked quietly at the grim old man.

“Three days,” she answered shortly. “Three days of spirit?soothing, then she will be sent into the Great Crucible.”

“That’s really short.” The warden snorted through his nose and looked up at the cemetery gate beside him. The black, carved iron fence stood like cold, sharp thorns under the lamp?light and the veil of night. Beyond this gate, which marked the line between life and death, one could faintly see many neat rows of stone slabs, the narrow paths between them, and deeper in, the blurred shapes of tombstones and small huts.

This was a cemetery, but for most of the bodies sent here, it was not their resting place for long. Aside from a few long?term graves with special meaning, the dead only stayed here for a time. From city officials at the top to peddlers and laborers at the bottom, no one could escape the rules here.

They died and were sent temporarily to the cemetery. Under the gaze of Bartok, God of Death, they slowly calmed down. After a few days at the shortest, or ten days or half a month at the longest, they would be sent into the Great Crucible next to the cemetery. The sins of their lives turned into smoke in the sky. The good they had done was merged into the hiss of the steam pipes. A bit of ash was scattered into the soil of the city?state, and nothing of them remained in the world.

The cemetery would keep only a small headstone for them—very small, and soon buried behind many more.

“The dead cannot take the living’s land,” the bandaged woman shook her head. “For the dead whose dying process was ‘clean and pure,’ three days are enough time for the soul to regain peace.”

“That’s not the only reason, is it?” The grim warden raised his eyes. His dry, cloudy eyeballs quietly watched the “bandaged woman” in the heavy black coat. “You’re afraid the corpses will get up—like in the recent rumors.”

“There is still no proof that the dead in the city are truly ‘coming back to life.’ The few reports we have even contradict one another. But even a short revival as a ‘Restless One’ is something to be careful about,” the bandaged woman shook her head. “So keep a close watch on your cemetery. As for what happens in the city, the Church and the city hall will handle it.”

“I hope things really are as simple as you say, Agatha,” the warden muttered. “I can guarantee that no corpse will walk out of this yard. But the ‘cemetery’ that you and your colleagues must guard is much larger than my little plot.”

The corpse?bearers carried the coffin into the cemetery. Their silent, black?clad figures looked like corpses walking along the paths between the slabs.

They found an empty, prepared stone platform, set the coffin on it, and then stood at the four corners, ready to carry out Bartok’s soothing ritual.

The warden and the black?robed priestess called “Agatha” also walked into the cemetery and came to the platform.

The four corpse?bearers took out talismans of Bartok. They were triangular metal sigils with a door?shaped relief in the center, symbolizing the gate between life and death. They placed these sigils at the four corners of the coffin, recited a short prayer in unison, and then stepped back half a step.

Agatha then stepped forward. She took off her wide?brimmed hat and looked at the coffin on the platform as the cold wind blew.

The gas lamp lit up her figure.

Layers of bandages wrapped her whole body and even covered half her face. In the places the bandages did not cover, one could still see a trace of delicate features and the soft lines unique to a woman. A head of dark brown, slightly wavy long hair hung down her back. In her equally dark brown eyes there was only calm and pity.

“May the favor of Bartok, God of Death, watch over your soul and let you regain peace in your last three days in this world… Your ties and debts to the mortal world are wiped clean today. Lost one, you may travel light on your way…”

Agatha’s low, hoarse benediction echoed through the silent cemetery and slowly sank into the deep night.

The grim?faced warden stood to the side, watching this ritual coldly. At some point, a heavy double?barreled shotgun had appeared in his hands. On the gun’s forearm one could faintly see a triangular sigil that symbolized Bartok, God of Death.

A moment later, the ritual ended. Agatha turned her head to look at the warden of the cemetery. “It’s done.”

“I hope your prayer works,” the warden said, lifting the shotgun in his hand, “though I trust this old partner of mine more.”

“This soothing ritual was carried out by the ‘Gatekeeper’ herself. It should have some effect,” Agatha said calmly. She put the heavy, black wide? brimmed hat back on, nodded to the warden, and then led the corpse? bearers toward the cemetery gate. “We should go.”

Bartok’s followers left. The black steam car moved farther and farther away under the veil of night until its tail lights slowly melted into the night of the city.

The cold night wind blew through the graveyard, over rows of stone platforms and the carved iron fence at the edge. The sullen old warden stood at the gate, watching the direction the hearse had gone. After a long time, he pulled his gaze back and drew his clothes tighter in the wind.

“The living are finally gone. I’m really not used to the cemetery being this lively.”

He muttered to himself as he gripped his trusty double?barreled shotgun and slowly walked toward his small warden’s hut beside the morgue.

A moment later, the old man came out of the hut again. This time, he held one more thing in his hand.

A small, pink?white flower, no one knew where he had picked it.

He went to the newest coffin and picked up a stone from beside it, using it to press the little flower at one corner of the platform.

The night wind blew along the path, making the fragile petals shiver. On the nearby rows of stone platforms, one could see the corners of many slabs

pressed with similar little flowers.

Most of the flowers had already withered in the wind.

“Sleep. Have a good sleep. It’s hard to sleep this soundly when you’re alive,” the old warden muttered. “Your family will come greet you tomorrow morning. That’s the rule. Say goodbye to them, then leave in peace. The world of the living isn’t all that good anyway…”

The old man shook his head, bent down to grab his double?barreled shotgun, turned, and slowly walked away.

…

“We’re sailing north. Our destination is Frostholm.” On the deck of the Vanished, Duncan found Vanna staring blankly at the distant sea and called out to her. “I’ve seen you looking off into the distance this whole time, so I guessed you were wondering about the ship’s course.”

“Frostholm?” Vanna was a little surprised. She had indeed been trying to guess the Vanished’s next route, but she had not expected Captain Duncan to bring it up to her on his own. “Why Frostholm? Did something happen there?”

“It started because Morris received a letter, a letter from a deceased friend,” Duncan said as he walked to the rail at the side of the deck. He placed both hands on the railing and looked at the Boundless Sea in the distant night. “But the bigger reason is that I’ve become interested in that place.”

“You’ve become interested?”

“In a sense, Frostholm counts as Alice’s ‘hometown,’” Duncan said with a smile. “Though she herself has no such idea at all.”

“…I don’t know much about Frostholm,” Vanna said. “I only know that its main faith is Bartok, God of Death, though there are also some believers of

the storm Goddess. Frostholm's own industry seems very developed, and the biggest pillar of its economy is the boiling gold mines…"

She paused here and then, without thinking, glanced toward the cabins.

"Of course, what Frostholm is most famous for is the rebellion half a century ago. Alice doesn't mind people talking about that, right?"

"She doesn't mind—because she doesn't understand a word of it."

"…All right."

Chapter 288: Touching Frostholm

The sea grew a little choppy.

The cold night wind blew over the water. Rolling waves crashed again and again against the sturdy hull of the Vanished, but the huge ship still kept a steady stance. It seemed to ignore the wind and waves and kept sailing north at full speed.

Under the veil of night, the half?transparent spirit form sails billowed high. Now and then, the ropes and masts gave off tight creaking sounds. The living ghost ship let out a pleased sigh in the wind and waves, but the new member on board looked rather troubled.

From Duncan, Vanna had learned the truth about the Frostholm rebellion fifty years ago. She had learned of the strange and eerie Abyssal Trench Project, and that even now, fifty years later, faint Shadows of that terrible plan still stretched on without end.

Compared with the world?ending great fire that had struck Pland, the Abyssal Trench Project that took place at Frostholm was a disaster on a different level. In the abyssal trench, dark, cold, formless horrors surged. The catastrophe might be about to happen, might already be happening, or might even have already ended. In the cold veil of night, no sound could describe the outline of that unseen terror.

The Black Sun incident in Pland had been a blazing, dazzling war. What happened under the abyssal sea at Frostholm was a silent, twisted nightmare.

“According to Tyrian, the Abyssal Trench Project already ended, and all later effects ended with the death of Frostholm’s queen. But in truth, we have no proof that some supernatural Vision under Frostholm has really stopped running. We do not even know what that thing is. The entire affair was shrouded in mist from beginning to end. And now Morris has received a letter from Frostholm. That letter is a signal, a reminder that something is wrong in that northern city?state.”

Duncan’s deep voice sounded in the night wind. Then he paused for a moment, suddenly turned his head, and looked at Vanna: “Did Helena ever tell you about the ‘disturbances’ in the Northern Seas?”

“Your Eminence?” Vanna froze for a second and then shook her head lightly. “She never said. She only told me to board the Vanished, but she did not actually tell me what I was supposed to do.”

“She did not say…” Duncan muttered softly, but did not stay on that topic. “Then do not think too much about it. Just get used to life on the ship. Do not worry, I will not give you any task that puts you in a difficult spot.”

He raised his head and looked at the deep night and the thin mist spread over the endless sea in the distance.

“It is very late. You should not stand on deck in this cold wind for too long. The night sea breeze is not kind to body or mind.”

Vanna gave Duncan a slightly surprised look—she had worn that surprised look many times over the whole day—then came back to her senses and nodded: “Ah, all right. Thank you.”

As she spoke, she felt around on herself and took a small piece of wood from the pocket of her shirt. It was a wave?shaped charm amulet carved from Sea?Breath Wood. She raised the charm amulet to her lips and softly

spoke a few lines of benediction. Then she threw it hard into the sea beyond the ship’s rail.

Duncan watched Vanna’s action with curiosity: “What are you doing?”

“That is a wave?shaped charm amulet I carved myself from Sea?Breath Wood. Believers of the storm Goddess use this way to pray when they go out to sea,” Vanna explained casually. “Sea?Breath Wood is seen as something the storm Goddess favors. Throwing a charm amulet made from it into the sea stands for an ancient sacrificial rite. Saying a benediction as you throw the charm amulet also makes it easier to form a link with the Goddess.”

She suddenly stopped here, then asked, a little unsure: “Do you mind this kind of act?”

“Ah, of course I do not mind. I told you, the atmosphere on the Vanished is more relaxed than you think,” Duncan said at once, smiling as he shook his head. “Morris also prays to the God of Wisdom from time to time.”

As he spoke, he waved to Vanna, then turned and slowly walked toward the captain’s cabin: “I will go back first. You should rest early.”

The sound of the rising and falling waves rushed like a steady roar. Vanna used her gaze to watch the tall figure go farther and farther away. Suddenly she seemed to think of something and called out behind Duncan: “Captain!”

Duncan stopped, but did not turn around: “What is it?”

Vanna opened her mouth. After hesitating for two or three seconds, she finally said: “I want to apologize to you—for my past recklessness…”

“I do not mind,” Duncan said casually. Then he waved his hand and walked off without looking back.

Vanna still stood on the deck, looking a little absent?minded.

Behind her, in the surging sea, the wave?shaped charm amulet carved from Sea?Breath Wood had been tossed up and down by the foam for a long time. Only now did a cresting wave catch it. In an instant, it was rolled down into the depths of the sea.

…

In the captain’s cabin, Goathead raised his head with a creaking sound and looked at Duncan as he walked into the room: “Ah, Captain, have you finished calming the new crew member? Today was truly an unbelievable day. A high?ranking priest of the storm Goddess has become your crew member. I think that can be seen as a kind of war trophy…”

Duncan lifted his eyelids and glanced at Goathead: “Then say that next time in front of Vanna.”

“…I cannot beat her.”

“Then stop talking nonsense,” Duncan said casually. As he walked past the enchanted sea chart, he lowered his head and glanced at it. “Where are we now? What is the situation with the Sea Mist?”

“The Sea Mist is still sailing at full speed, but it adjusted its course twice not long ago. From its position, it may already be near the secret home port of the Sea Mist fleet,” Goathead answered at once. “We should reach the Frost Sea before dawn. Then, if we sail north for four or five more days, we will arrive near Frostholm… Are we going straight there, or moving in secret in the nearby waters?”

“Do not reveal ourselves for now,” Duncan said. “I am not planning to have a ‘warm meeting’ with Frostholm’s Guard Corps yet.”

“Yes, Captain.”

Duncan thought for a moment, then said: “Also, after the Sea Mist stops, move closer and take a look. Without exposing ourselves, scout the position

of Tyrian’s secret Harbor and the area around it. For the Vanished, which can hide in the Spirit Realm for long periods, that should not be hard.”

“Ah, of course, that is easy,” Goathead agreed at once. “But… why do you want to scout that secret Harbor?”

“If something really has gone wrong in Frostholm, and it is linked to the secret under the abyssal sea, I think Tyrian will take action. Watching him will be the same as watching Frostholm. If the conditions there are right, we will lie in wait near the Sea Mist.”

Goathead accepted the order at once: “Understood.”

Duncan nodded and walked toward his own cabin.

“I am going to try to ‘probe’ the situation in Frostholm’s direction. Do not disturb me unless it is necessary.”

“Yes, Captain!”

The door of the cabin closed behind him.

Duncan let out a light breath, went to the table, and sat down. He rolled his slightly stiff shoulders and neck.

Ai, who had been resting with her eyes closed by the window, woke up. She flapped her wings, hopped onto the table, tilted her head, and looked at her Master: “Food only, or staying the night?”

Duncan gave the pigeon a sideways glance: “A walk in the Spirit Realm.”

As soon as he spoke, the brass spirit compass hanging on Ai’s chest snapped open with a click. Ghost?green flame rose from inside the spirit compass. In an instant, the scene in Duncan’s sight changed.

He once again came to that boundless, chaotic dark space filled with countless starlights and lines.

Ai’s figure appeared in the darkness. The skeletal bird wrapped in spirit form fire circled and flew around him.

But he did not move at once or touch any cluster of nearby starlight. First he calmed himself, carefully watched the lights that flickered in his view, and felt the faint breaths that came from them.

As expected… as the Vanished moved farther from Pland and closer to Frostholm, the starlights he saw in this space also changed.

Duncan raised his head and sensed his body in Pland. Along that sense, he looked into the depths of the darkness and saw a hazy patch of light far, far away.

He then drew his gaze back from the distance and looked at the bright “stars” that flickered before him.

After thinking for a moment, he moved closer to some of the lights and carefully touched a few.

He did not directly take over the bodies that the lights stood for. Instead, he used this way to read the shallow information behind the lights—emotions, senses, and even broken fragments of surface awareness.

Cold. Nervousness. Fuel prices. Steam supply. City Hall. Frostholm…

After touching a few lights, Duncan withdrew his will.

If he kept touching these lights that stood for “living people,” he might cause panic on a larger scale, and that in turn might draw the attention of the city?state’s Guardians. He still did not want to deal with an unfamiliar Church.

The information he had now was enough. Just from what he read from those few lights, he could already be sure that this patch of starlight belonged to the residents of Frostholm.

At least, it was part of them.

Duncan let his gaze sweep across the dazzling starlight, looking for those individuals whose light was dim and weak, whose life force was fading.

He needed a fated body to serve as a forward post for gathering information.

After a moment, a faint light that flickered in an Anomaly?like way suddenly caught his eye.

“You will do!”

Chapter 289: Coffin and Warden

A dim cluster of starlight with an Anomaly?like flicker drew Duncan’s attention.

That faint light was slightly different from the lights around it. Its weak, unreal glow was like a transparent phantom, and its unsteady flicker made it seem ready to fade away at any moment. Duncan had seen weak flashes in this chaotic space before, but even the weakest of them did not look so unreal and close to vanishing.

He frowned slightly.

A weak light often meant a body that had only recently died. But what did it mean when the light was weak and at the same time almost transparent and unreal?

He stretched out a finger and lightly touched that point of light.

In the next second, he felt his consciousness cross an endless distance at once, leaving the Vanished and falling into a new body. Cold and numb sensations spread through his limbs and bones. Then the numbness slowly faded. He began to feel the touch on his skin and the slow beating of his heart.

But for some reason, this new body felt especially heavy. Controlling it was like moving through a thick Veil. He used a great deal of effort just to move a finger, and the same effort just to force his eyelids open a crack.

Everything in front of him was dark.

[Was this a blind person? Or were the eyes covered?]

Duncan raised his hand by instinct, groping to check his eyes. As soon as he lifted his arm, he felt it hit something hard and cold. He lifted his other arm, and it also bumped into something.

He felt around on all sides and finally realized he was trapped in some kind of… container.

It was a coffin.

Duncan lay quietly in the darkness for a long moment before he sighed: “All right. That is reasonable…”

When you possessed a corpse, ending up trapped in a coffin really was the reasonable outcome. The last two times, when he had possessed bodies without any limit, had been the rare ones.

But why did it have to become reasonable at this time!

A mix of annoyance and helpless amusement rose in his heart. Duncan felt he now understood, at least a little, how Dog and Vanna had felt before when they faced “reasonable developments on the Vanished” and were left speechless. But this was clearly not the time to keep feeling things—he had to find a way to get out of this coffin.

Otherwise, he would have to give up this hard?won fated body, go back to that dark chaotic space, and choose another target to possess. He might very well end up trapped in another coffin.

Duncan began to move his hands and feet, getting used to the senses of this strange, hard?to?use body while he also tried to push open the lid above his head. A moment ago, by knocking on the wood around him, he had judged from the hollow thumping sound that this coffin was not buried in the ground. It was likely only placed somewhere for now. That meant that as long as he pushed open the lid above him, he could get out.

But the coffin lid was harder to deal with than he had thought. The lid was nailed shut and might even have extra locks. The body he now occupied was too “poor in quality.” From the feeling in his limbs, it was even weaker and more powerless than the corpse he had first taken over at the sacrificial rite site in the sewers. Forget forcing open a nailed coffin lid; even moving around a little was hard.

[Just how weak was this dead body?]

“Hey! Is anyone out there? I think I can still be saved! Call a Doctor—if that does not work, a Coroner will do…”

As he pushed at the coffin lid above him, Duncan began to shout in helpless complaint. He did not care if he scared someone or drew trouble. After a short time of adjusting and sensing, he had already confirmed that the state of this body was Anomaly?level bad, completely unfit for long?term use. It was probably a one?time shell, just like the “sacrificial victim” he had taken over the first time. Since it was a one?time shell… there was nothing to worry about.

No matter who he drew here, as long as they could get him up so he could see the surroundings, it would be enough. If he was lucky, he might even gather some information. In any case, the worst that could happen was that he died stuck in this coffin. It would not get worse than that.

He even had time now to let his thoughts wander and wondered if he should ask Alice for tips—how had that Doll managed to escape from a coffin whose lid had been nailed down and wrapped in several layers of iron chains? Just by relying on her natural strength?

In the silent corpse yard of the cemetery, the dull banging and the hoarse, low calls sounded especially abrupt.

The Warden, of course, did not ignore this sudden strange noise.

The door of the Warden’s hut was pushed open. The light of a consecrated lantern lit the small path outside the wooden house that led to the corpse yard. A gloomy old man with a fierce gaze and a hunched back stepped out of the hut. He held the consecrated lantern in one hand and gripped a powerful double?barreled shotgun in the other. His yellow, cloudy eyes stared hard in the direction of the sound.

“…The cemetery is far too lively tonight.”

The old man muttered in a harsh tone. He hung the consecrated lantern on a metal hook at his waist, traced a Triangular Emblem over his chest, then raised the shotgun and slowly walked toward the coffins.

That coffin was still thumping. The dead inside the coffin kept stubbornly knocking on the barrier between him and the world of the living, and as he knocked, he kept asking the people outside to help him get free.

“Is anyone there? Come help me out. I think this is a misdiagnosis!”

“Quiet down!” The Warden held the shotgun ready. The click of the safety being removed sounded especially sharp in the night. The stooped old man stared at the coffin and shouted: “You should be sleeping. You now belong to another world. There is no place for you in the world of the living.”

The knocking inside the coffin suddenly stopped.

Duncan judged the sound outside. It should be an old man, very close to him, and just now there had been a light clink of metal parts, probably from a weapon.

Having someone there made things easier. This way, whether he got out or not, he had another way to reach information from the outside.

“Hello, I want to know what is going on,” Duncan said after clearing his throat. He thought about how to make the most of this body so he could get more information from the person outside the coffin. “I am trapped in

this… coffin, but there must be some mistake. I am still alive. Listen, my voice is actually quite strong."

"Breathing is a common illusion for the dead. Attachment to the world of the living is an obsession that your subconscious leaves in the outer layers of your brain. That truly is hard to accept, but Bartok has already prepared a better resting place for your soul," the old caretaker said, staring at the coffin. One hand still held the shotgun, while the other quietly traced the sign of the God of Death in the air. Then he took a small packet of dried powder from his clothes, rubbed some of the powder along the shotgun's barrels, and scattered the rest on the ground. "Lie down and be quiet. You should already feel sleepy. That is the call of the Lord of Death. Obey it. That will be best for both of us."

The doctrine of the Lord of Death Bartok—Duncan silently took note of this. Then he cleared his throat and kept bargaining: "…But I still think I can be saved. What if it is a misdiagnosis?"

The old caretaker with the shotgun frowned. For some reason, he felt that tonight's "Restless One" was not like any he had met in his career. The voice in the coffin sounded a bit too rational and even knew how to bargain. But he soon shook his head and pushed these messy thoughts aside:

"With respect, you slipped and fell from the guardrail of the shaft, dropped straight into a mine passage a hundred meters deep, and the back of your head burst open. The mortician took a lot of work to piece your skull back together. Mister, as I see it, the chance of a misdiagnosis in your case is… very low."

Listening to the voice outside the coffin, Duncan silently raised his hand and touched the back of his head.

"…All right. I admit my injuries sound a bit serious. In this state, this body really is not fit to leave the coffin," he sighed. "Sorry to bother you."

The old caretaker was silent for a few seconds. Then he quietly lit another spare consecrated lantern at his waist and hung it on the wooden post closest to the corpse table, all while saying calmly: “No need to be polite. Compared with most Restless Ones, you are still rather polite.”

“Oh? Do you run into this kind of thing often?”

“Every year, there are always a few corpses that do not want to stay in their coffins. Most of them try to get out in a more violent way. Only a very small number try to solve the problem by talking,” the old caretaker muttered. “But even the ones who know how to talk only speak confused nonsense. The dead always think they can achieve True Resurrection, but in fact… the great door of Bartok is not so easy to cross.”

The old caretaker shook his head and kept talking while watching the flame in the consecrated lantern on the nearby post. He knew the dead had no real reason. That was only the afterglow of a Restless Soul’s obsession. In conversation, that kind of “afterglow” burned out even faster. When the one in the coffin used up his reason, the old man’s “extra work” for the night would be done.

“Restless One, Living dead, True Resurrection—these are three completely different things,” the old man rambled on. “To cross those boundaries, you need amazing power, must bear great pain, and also need a very rare chance. Mister, do not make things hard on yourself. You cannot cross them.”

Chapter 290: Visitor in the Cemetery

He guessed that the place he was in now was a public facility used to store corpses for a while. The voice outside the coffin should belong to the warden who ran this place.

The warden sounded very experienced. He calmly called the strange movement from the coffin a “Restless One” phenomenon and spoke with Duncan in a clear, sensible way. During the whole time, he did not show any panic at all.

The body Duncan was using now seemed to belong to a worker from a mine. The cause of death was a fall from a great height, and the body had suffered serious physical damage.

While he talked with the voice outside the coffin, Duncan quietly summed up this useful information. At the same time, he became even more certain that this body was not very useful.

Even if he did not think about how weak this body felt because of the anomaly, it would still be hard for him to go running around with a caved? in skull. Of course, this world did have “Living dead”. The sailors on Tyrian’s ship included more than a few strange fellows whose skulls were missing a piece or whose hearts were missing a chunk. But even as a Living dead, one could not just walk around openly in a city?state. That did not meet his needs at all.

While Duncan made his plans in silence, the old caretaker outside the coffin kept his nerves tight and never relaxed.

The double?barreled shotgun in the old man’s hands still pointed at the coffin. The herbal powder he had spread on the ground earlier now gave off a pale glow. His voice stayed calm, but his fingers on the gun were already turning white.

He was waiting for the Restless One in the coffin to use up the last of its obsession and reason. He was waiting for that talkative dead man to grow tired and accept the fact of his own death. According to his experience, this usually did not take long. Under the strong soothing effect of the consecrated lantern and the herbs, half an hour was often enough to calm a restless soul.

Normally, the dead would slowly grow dull and muddled as they talked. Very soon, they would even forget how to speak at all. Normally, the voice in the coffin would turn into vague muttering, then into hoarse rambling. Normally…

So why did the one in this coffin seem more and more energetic the more he talked?!

“You know where I am right now? Ah, of course I know this is a place for keeping corpses. I mean where it is exactly… You know, I couldn’t see anything around me when they brought me here.

“How’s the weather today? It should be pretty cold, right? I think I can hear the wind outside. Frostholm nights are hard to get through…

“What time is it now? Have you eaten? Do you have any coworkers with you?

“Any news in the city lately? I don’t really remember what happened before… Oh, right, do you know someone named Brown Scott? I think he’s

a folklore scholar or maybe a historian. He lives on Hearth Street. A friend of mine knows him very well…”

Fine beads of sweat slowly appeared on the old caretaker’s forehead. He could swear to Bartok that in all his long career he had never seen such a strange case. A restless corpse, after having a “Gatekeeper” from the Church of Death personally perform a soul?calming ritual on it, and under the strong soothing of the consecrated lantern and the herbal powder, showed not the slightest sign of going to sleep. Instead it was waking up more and more, like a living person!

This could not help but make him think of the troubling rumors that had been spreading through the city?state lately. He thought of all those stories about “the return of the dead”.

Had the boundary that Bartok, God of Death, had set between life and death really developed a gap?

“Mister,” the old caretaker tightened his grip on the shotgun. His tone grew a bit more serious as he said: “You’ve said enough. If I were you, I’d quiet down right now and go back to proper sleep as soon as possible – otherwise, when the Sun comes up, you’re the one who’ll suffer.”

Duncan thought for a moment inside the coffin, then said helplessly: “I’d really like to cooperate with you, but I honestly can’t fall asleep right now… How about you help me open this lid and then give me a good medicine for calming the mind and helping sleep?”

“Now you’re asking for too much…”

The old caretaker spoke in a low voice, but just then, a sudden, harsh pounding on the iron gate at the cemetery entrance cut him off.

Who would visit at such a late hour of the night?

The old caretaker looked in shock toward the source of the pounding. He saw several figures in black coats standing under the streetlamp outside the tall carved gate. The glow from the gas lamp fell on them, stretching their shadows long and wrapping their backs in a halo of light.

One of the figures raised a hand and showed something in the lamplight.

It was a triangular metal sigil, the symbol of an envoy of Bartok, God of Death.

The old caretaker’s heart gave a little jolt. He turned back without thinking and glanced at the brand?new coffin.

The voice inside the coffin had gone quiet for the moment.

After a short hesitation, the old man turned and walked quickly toward the cemetery entrance.

With a clatter of loosening chains and the creak of turning hinges, the tall cemetery gate swung open.

The old caretaker lifted his head and studied the figures under the streetlamp with wary eyes.

Three men and one woman, all wearing thick, pitch?black coats and equally heavy wide?brimmed hats. They stood in silence in the night wind. Their clothes and their quiet stance made people think of a Crow standing by a gravestone at midnight.

While the old man was looking up at these uninvited guests, the uninvited guests were also studying this gloomy old gravekeeper. Very soon, a shorter man stepped half a step forward, lifted the triangular sigil in his hand, and spoke in a solemn voice:

“The peace of death will in the end shelter you and me. By order of the city’s Cathedral, we have come to take away one of the dead. He should

have just been sent to this cemetery.”

“priests of the God of Death?” The old caretaker felt a flash of doubt. He frowned slightly at the triangular sigil in the man’s hand. “Gatekeeper Agatha left only a few hours ago. She didn’t say any other priests would be coming here to guide the dead. And… it’s midnight. This is not a good time to guide the dead.”

“Special case. This dead man needs to be taken somewhere safer,” another person among the visitors spoke. It was the woman. She was of medium height, her facial lines were hard and cold, and her lips were very thin. “Please cooperate. It’s a matter of life and death. There can be no delay.”

When the old caretaker heard the words “special case”, his heart moved. He thought again of the talkative voice in that coffin, and at once all his doubts faded.

It seemed the Restless One in that coffin really was unusual, and the Church had already noticed. He did not know how the priests at the Cathedral had made their judgment, but in any case, the experts were here now.

The old man did not like outsiders disturbing his cemetery, but since the other side held the proper emblem of the God of Death and claimed to be official priests, there was no need for him to stand in their way.

He only hoped this trouble would end as soon as possible tonight.

“Come with me,” the old man muttered. He turned and stepped aside, opening the way into the cemetery. “You came at just the right time.”

“Just the right time?” One of the tall, broad?shouldered men in black was about to follow him in. He paused for a moment at those words. “Why do you say that?”

“That corpse has already started to get restless. Ha, muttering and rambling, talking nonstop, the more we talk the more awake he gets. I’m starting to

think he’ll cross the First Threshold and turn into an Undying – and that would be a real problem. The nearby residents wouldn’t like that at all,” the old caretaker said, shaking his head. “Nobody likes the Undying. People in Frostholm like them even less. It makes them think of that battleship cursed by the curse. That ship was full of Undying…”

As they listened to the old man grumble all the way, the four people in black traded quick glances, as if a bit surprised.

But soon, the thin?lipped woman shook her head slightly, signaling them to hold back for now.

The other three nodded a little and kept following the old caretaker in silence. The short man who had shown the Church emblem earlier casually tossed the sigil onto the ground.

The emblem fell without a sound. The moment it touched the earth, it turned into drifting black dust and blew away on the wind.

The group soon crossed the narrow paths of the cemetery and reached the morgue where the dead were stored for a time.

Plain coffins sat in neat rows on raised platforms, lying silent in the night wind. The consecrated lantern the old caretaker had hung on a post earlier still burned with a steady flame. The herbal powder on the ground still gave off a faint pale glow.

Seeing that these sealing measures were still working normally, the old caretaker clearly relaxed a little. He then took two steps forward and pointed at the newest coffin: “This one. The one you’re looking for. It was brought in tonight.”

The four people in black exchanged a look. The thin?lipped woman walked up to the platform and frowned slightly as she looked over the coffin in front of her: “…So this is it…”

“Probably,” Duncan said casually from inside the coffin. “Who are you?”

The woman’s eyes widened a little at once, as if the voice from the coffin had startled her. The other three men clearly jumped as well. They looked at each other nervously, and the tall one could not help but mutter under his breath: “Something’s not right…”

“What’s not right?” The old caretaker seemed to have very good hearing. He asked curiously: “Is it too much for you to handle?”

“No, we’re here to take care of it,” the woman in black answered right away. Then she glanced at her three companions, as if weighing her words quickly, and nodded to the old caretaker: “From here… we’ll need you to step aside for a while.”

Chapter 291: Seeing Through

When he heard this priest of the God of Death, the old caretaker did not cooperate at once like an ordinary gravekeeper. Instead, he frowned in displeasure: “I’m the cemetery’s warden. I’ve never heard of any operation in a cemetery that needed the warden to leave.”

“Special case, old mister,” the short man in black stepped half a step forward. His tone was serious and sincere. When he saw the stubborn look on the old caretaker’s face, he finally sighed. “Fine, I wasn’t supposed to tell you this. This corpse is to be sent to the Silent Cathedral.”

“The Silent Cathedral?” the old caretaker blurted out. “What in the world…”

“Severe unknown corruption, possibly related to something deep in the mine. We have to carry out a special purification ritual. The fewer living people at the scene, the better,” the short man said gravely. “It’s not just you who has to step aside. One of my colleagues and I will step aside with you as well.”

As he spoke, the tall, broad?shouldered man in black also stepped forward and silently came to stand beside the short man.

The old caretaker looked at the two black?clad priests in front of him, then at the woman in black who stood by the corpse platform. She had already taken herbs and holy oil from her bag and started laying out a temporary altar on the open ground in front of the platform.

“All right. If it involves the mine and corruption, then it’s not my job anymore,” the old man finally gave up his stubbornness. He shrugged, put away the shotgun, and turned toward the cemetery path. Then he looked back and called to the tall and short men in black: “Come. I’ve got some hot tea in my little hut. You can warm up by the fire. The cemetery at night is even colder than outside.”

The two men in black exchanged a look, then followed the old man and said casually: “Thank you for the hospitality, old mister.”

The old caretaker and the two men in black left. By the corpse platform, only the thin?lipped woman in black and the other, thin and silent man remained.

And one coffin, now quiet.

Duncan lay quietly inside the coffin. He thought over his talk with the warden and tried to guess where these uninvited guests had come from.

This landing trip to Frostholm really was not like the last time in Pland. It did not look very smooth, but it had its own kind of fun.

The only thing that displeased him was this body’s poor performance.

He lifted his hand inside the coffin and watched a tiny green flame dance at his fingertip, lighting up the cramped space.

Luckily, the fire of his spirit form was not affected at all.

In the wavering green light, he saw cheap, low?grade planks, coarse linen lining, and the coffin lid covered in dense runes. In the middle of those runes sat a triangular sigil – it should be the mark of Bartok, God of Death.

Those runes and that emblem were clearly not some “fine handmade work”. They were probably stamped on directly by machine. The effect was about the same anyway.

Duncan pricked up his ears again and listened carefully to the sounds outside the coffin.

The coffin was thin and not well sealed. He could clearly hear people talking outside. Just now, he had heard the warden and two of the visitors walking away. Now he heard faint rustling sounds, as if the people who had stayed behind were moving around near the coffin.

What are they going to do?

The woman in black stopped arranging the altar in front of the corpse platform.

She stood up and glanced toward the path where the warden had left. After she made sure the stubborn old caretaker had gone far away, she spat on the ground, then walked toward the coffin.

She stepped right over the “altar” she had just set up, not caring about it at all. The herbal powder and the clay dish that held the oil were kicked aside with one careless swing of her foot.

The silent man in black had already reached the coffin. He gave his gatekeeper’s cane a shake. A metal hook popped out from the end of the cane, turning it into a crowbar.

“Hold on,” the woman in black raised a hand to stop her partner, then came up to the coffin and knocked on the lid with her knuckles. “Still there?”

“Ah, yes,” Duncan answered at once. “Do you need something?”

The woman in black frowned, looking a bit puzzled, but her face quickly turned blank again. “Do you know who you are?” she asked.

“…No idea,” Duncan lied smoothly. “In fact, I’m still confused. I don’t know how I ended up here. Just now, a warden from the cemetery told me

I’m already dead and will be burned in three days… What in the world happened? And who are you?”

“Ah, we’re here to help you,” the woman in black said lightly. “You don’t want to be burned, do you?”

“Of course not. Frostholm’s winter is really cold, but warming up in a crematorium sounds a bit too challenging. Are you going to let me out?”

“Your jokes are as cold as this night, mister,” the woman in black laughed. “Of course we’ll let you out. Then you only need to come with us, and you won’t have to worry about anyone giving you trouble again.”

“Then thank you very much,” the voice in the coffin said politely.

The woman in black put away her smile and stepped back half a step. She nodded to the silent man holding the crowbar: “Pry it open.”

The silent man stepped forward at once. With a squeak and creak of wood, the not?so?sturdy coffin was soon forced open. Then he gave the lid a push with the gatekeeper’s cane, shoving the dark board all the way aside.

The plank slid off the platform and fell heavily onto the gravel.

The woman in black raised a finger in a hush gesture. At the same time, a hoarse, low murmur came from her throat, a sound that did not seem human at all.

As she made this gesture, the coffin lid hit the ground without making any sound. In the blink of an eye, the heavy plank turned into drifting black dust and disappeared silently into the veil of night.

Then the man and woman in black lifted their heads and looked into the now wide?open coffin.

A pale man with large hands and feet, wearing a dark brown coat, sat up inside and looked back at them in curiosity.

After a long moment, a faint smile appeared on Duncan’s face. He sighed softly: “Ah, things do seem to be getting interesting.”

“What did you say?” The woman in black frowned. Then she quickly hardened her face and spoke in a low voice that seemed to carry a strange power: “Climb out and leave this place with us at once.”

“No hurry,” Duncan said, still sitting in the coffin. He smiled and shook his head. “The chains on you are really something – and your Abyssal demons are quite something too. I thought only Dog came with that kind of thing.”

The man and woman in black both froze. The next second, they showed clear shock. The thin?lipped woman even took half a step back without thinking. She stared hard at Duncan sitting in the coffin, shock and caution in her eyes: “You can see through our disguise?!”

“Disguise?”

Duncan raised his eyebrows and let his gaze sweep over the two in front of him.

The woman wore a dark dress. Her face was thin and mean. Between her neck and collarbone, a pitch?black chain grew out. The chain was clearly part of her body, as if it extended straight from her bones. Its end was linked to an ugly monster bird, its whole body twisted together from black bone plates.

Black smoke rose from the monster bird. It perched steadily on the woman’s shoulder. Two bloody holes in its skull stared fixedly at Duncan, and every single bone plate on its body trembled faintly.

The other was a thin man in a thick gray?blue coat. A chain stretched straight out from his throat. The other end was linked to a huge jellyfish floating in the air. The jellyfish seemed to have no real body at all. Its whole

form was made of drifting smoke. Deep inside it was a blood?red core that kept swelling and shrinking, writhing like a heart.

Black chains and eerie, smoke?wrapped creatures, bound together in a symbiotic pact.

Clearly, two Annihilators.

And both cultists now looked shocked.

“Ah, right, disguise,” Duncan said at last, as if the word had only just clicked in his mind. He then slowly rose from the coffin and carefully climbed down from the platform. His movements were very slow, because this body really did not work well. “Dog seems to have a talent for messing with perception and helping people in symbiotic pacts hide their identity. So this is your common trick, huh? But with all due respect, your disguise skills are really not that reliable. I haven’t seen a single time they didn’t go wrong…”

“Stop!” The woman cultist finally came back to her senses. She suddenly retreated several steps, then raised her hand and pointed at Duncan. The words that came from her throat seemed to mix with another low, rasping voice, as if another spellcaster were speaking through her: “I strip you of the ability to move. I order you to stop where you are!”

Duncan had just stepped off the platform. He took two more unhurried steps forward and looked curiously at the woman in the distance: “So this is the so?called ‘spell’ that Annihilators borrow from the mouths of demons?

“Well, to be fair, it is a bit more elegant than Shirley.

“But from the look of it, it still doesn’t work as well as Meteor Dog – at least that one can make me jump.”

Chapter 292: Ignorance Is Bliss

The spell they cast through the symbiotic pact, using the forbidden knowledge shared by the Abyssal Demons, did nothing at all. Compared to a corpse that had woken early in its coffin, this bizarre failure of the spell shocked the two Annihilators at the scene even more.

Besides, the Death-Omen Bird was one of the Abyssal Demons whose Spells were strongest in the first place.

The gaunt, sharp-faced woman in the black dress stared in disbelief at the Revived One standing calmly in front of her. Black chains spread from her collarbone, and uneasy smoke drifted over their surface. At the same time, she sensed something wrong with the Death-Omen Bird bound to her by the symbiotic pact. The Abyssal Demon kept sending out signals of extreme danger. It even wanted to cut off its link to its Master and retreat back to the Abyssal Deep.

She finally reacted. She grabbed the chain at the Death-Omen Bird's feet with one hand. Her other hand closed on empty air as she stared hard into Duncan's eyes: "Something is wrong… you are not this dead man… who are you?"

Duncan looked at the woman, then at the silent man standing not far away, still keeping his distance and gripping the crowbar-like Gatekeeper's cane. He said: "You tell me who you are first. Let me guess… first, you two are obviously not Envoys of the Death God. You fooled that Warden with… hmm, so?called 'disguise tricks'. You came for me—or rather, for the body I am using right now. I'm not wrong, am I?"

The woman in the black dress parted her lips. Her mouth moved as if she were saying something, but Duncan did not catch it. The next second, she suddenly raised the right hand she had been holding in the air. Her low, muffled murmur turned into a strange shriek!

The Death-Omen Bird Demon perched on her shoulder spread its wings at the same moment. Under the control of the symbiotic pact, the Abyssal Demon had to fight against its instinctive fear and launch an attack at Duncan.

A heavy pressure suddenly fell. Then the ground underfoot began to shudder and twist in an unnatural way. The earth around Duncan rippled like liquid, and several huge black thorns, like bone spurs, shot up from the soil and coiled toward him.

Yet Duncan made no move to dodge. Mainly, this awful temporary body really could not handle any nimble response. He only watched calmly as the thorns reached him and wrapped around his body.

Then a grand spirit form flame rose from the thorns. In an instant, the thorny growth conjured by the spell turned into a field of pitch?black ash. Tiny leftover sparks drifted away on the wind.

“I told you, you might as well swing that bird on your shoulder and smash it into me. That might actually startle me.”

Duncan sighed helplessly, but as soon as he finished speaking, he felt something wrong with his body.

He raised his hands without thinking. The next second, he stared in shock as crack after crack opened on them.

These were not wounds from the thorns just now, but splits that appeared on their own. Under Duncan’s gaze, the cracks kept spreading, as if this body’s

skin and flesh had suddenly lost all life and elasticity and were drying and splitting in the cold, dry air.

Very little blood seeped from the cracks. Instead, dry, broken fragments kept falling from the wounds onto the ground. In just a few seconds, Duncan clearly felt this already weak body grow even more fragile.

He watched the strange change on his body in surprise. Then he lifted his head and looked at the woman in the black dress: “Is this also the power of a spell? It worked this time?”

The woman in the black dress still had not recovered from the shock of the thorns failing so completely. Her face had gone very pale, and the Death-Omen Bird on her shoulder drooped its head weakly. But when she heard Duncan’s words, a slight smile suddenly appeared on her face: “Ah. It seems this body is almost at its limit… that will make you much easier to deal with.”

“At its limit?” Duncan asked without thinking. He seemed to have guessed something from her tone and words. But just as he was about to say more, the woman in the black dress spoke in an icy voice: “Do it.”

As soon as she finished, the thin, quiet man beside her moved. Expressionless, he looked at Duncan. The Abyssal Demon floating in the air beside him, shaped like a Smokewisp Jellyfish, swelled and shrank. A mass of dark substance, spitting thick smoke, spat out from its body and shot at Duncan like a cannonball.

But the “acid shell” turned a faint green halfway there. Before it even touched its target, it broke apart and vanished without a sound.

Duncan watched the mass of darkness burst apart, helpless: “I told you, that thing doesn’t—”

He did not finish. The smoke and sparks in midair faded away, and when they cleared, he saw the silent man not far away already raising the Gatekeeper’s cane at him. The Gatekeeper’s cane had split open. A dark, wide gun barrel jutted out from the break.

“Bang!!”

Fire burst from the barrel, but the sound did not travel beyond the mortuary slab. The woman in the black dress had already raised a finger in a hush gesture.

The large?caliber bullet tore through the air, making only a low rumble inside the silenced area. Duncan’s eyes tracked the last part of its path, but he did nothing. He only glanced from the corner of his eye at the silent man who shared a symbiotic pact with the jellyfish?like Demon.

In the next second, his vision fell into brief darkness.

The special bullet’s impact ripped his head to pieces. Everything above his neck was gone.

Duncan’s body swayed. It stood there for a moment as if thinking, then lifted a hand and touched the space above its neck. When it found nothing, the body raised its hand toward the woman in the black dress and the silent man and gave them the middle finger. After that, it fell straight backward.

The woman in the black dress stared fixedly at that strange and terrifying headless body.

She had watched her companion blow its head apart with one shot. Then she watched the body raise a hand to touch the missing head and make that bizarre gesture. No body that had lost its head could move like that.

Whatever it was, the thing that had taken this body had not died. It had only left. This was only a temporary banishment.

Knowing it would be dangerous to stay, the woman in the black dress had already decided to give up tonight's operation. She looked up at her companion at once: "We're leaving. We'll signal the other two after we get out of the graveyard. Something is very wrong tonight…"

The silent man holding the strange Gatekeeper's cane did not move for a moment, as if he had not heard her.

He simply stood there. On the black chain that rose from his throat, a tiny green spark of fire flashed and vanished.

That ember had already flowed along the chain into his flesh.

His heart had already been burned to ash.

"Hey, did you hear me?" The woman's voice came again, stern and impatient. "We need to leave. If that Warden notices, there has been way too much noise tonight!"

The thin man with the Gatekeeper's cane nodded and slowly turned around.

"What was with you just now?" The woman in the black dress stared at her companion, then quickly looked away. "All right. We have to leave at once, Duncan."

"Of course," Duncan said with a smile. "This is no place to linger."

The woman in the black dress nodded and started to turn toward the path. But at the instant she began to turn her head, the Death-Omen Bird that had been resting on her shoulder suddenly let out a sharp, eerie scream. The bony plates all over the Abyssal Demon rattled, and black dust and smoke billowed from it. Then it whipped its head around and locked its gaze on Duncan, its wings twitching as it made a series of strange clicking sounds.

Behind Duncan, the jellyfish?shaped Abyssal Demon suddenly burst into roaring flame. In the thick black smoke and fire, the bodiless jellyfish

Demon burned away in seconds, as if from nothing. The chain that linked it to its symbiotic pact partner gave off a harsh clatter and fell to the ground as a pile of broken links.

The woman in the black dress stopped dead.

Through the chain between them, she felt the Death-Omen Bird's immense fear and its warning that brushed right against death.

She even vaguely sensed the Death-Omen Bird's visual signal. When the Demon on her shoulder turned toward Duncan, a sharp pain like a spike pierced her brain. Her retinas seemed to burn, and indescribable twisting light and shadow filled her reddening, darkening vision.

Ordinary Abyssal Demons had no heart. They moved only by instinct. When great danger appeared, they would not, like Dog, worry about their Master's mental health.

"Ugh—" The woman in the black dress let out a low cry. In pain and dazed, she stumbled back two steps and grabbed the nearby streetlamp for support. She stared in horror at the thin figure standing in the crisscrossing light and shadow under the lamp, a figure both familiar and strange: "You… what are you?"

Duncan glanced at the ugly skeletal bird on her shoulder [much uglier than AI], then turned to look at the little patch of black ash on the ground behind him. He sighed with regret.

"Ignorance is bliss," he said, shaking his head. "You were not blessed with much."

Chapter 293: Hunt and Escape

The moment Duncan said the words “Ignorance is bliss,” the woman in the black dress reacted.

But this time, she did not try any more useless attacks. She grabbed the chain at the Death-Omen Bird’s feet with one hand, swept her other hand behind her, and summoned a veil of hazy black mist in the air. Then she turned and ran toward the graveyard gate.

She no longer cared about the partner whose body had been taken, or about the other two companions still dealing with the Warden. The strange events of this night had already gone beyond what she could understand. Even as an Annihilator who had signed a symbiotic pact with a Abyssal Demon, she was close to the limits of her reason and courage.

She had to get away, as far and as fast as possible. She could not stay any longer under the unseen, unspeakable gaze of those Intruders, or remain in the company of those terrible Shadows.

Duncan frowned. He had not yet fully adjusted to the body he had just taken. He could feel that this body was clearly healthier than the one from the coffin, but it was still hard for him to keep up with her as she fled.

Even so, he still set off after her. As he walked, he casually tore apart the strange black mist she left in her path, got used to his new body, and kept his eyes on her fleeing back.

Under his gaze, the gas streetlamps the panicked woman passed began to flicker. A smear of deep green suddenly tainted their once steady, bright

flames.

The lamps corrupted by the Flame Usurper were like invisible footsteps. They followed the fleeing cultist's shadow, spreading quickly toward the graveyard gate and scattering more and more green sparks along the way.

But just as the green flames from the lamps on both sides were about to catch up with the cultist, the strange bird built from black bone plates suddenly shot into the air with a shrill scream. Its skeletal wings flung clouds of smoke across the night sky. Its sharp cry seemed to rip open a small patch of space and time. Duncan saw dark cracks suddenly split open in the shadow beside the cultist. Those blurred, twisted cracks then merged into a huge black hole.

The skeletal bird screamed in mad terror and hurled itself toward the dark opening that had appeared from nowhere. The chain that extended from its feet snapped straight. With a harsh clatter, the woman in the black dress was yanked toward the hole.

"Damn it! Stop! You bastard! You beast!" The cultist thrashed and screamed, her voice breaking with sheer panic and despair. "No, no! Don't! Don't take me to the Abyssal Deep… help, help! No! No—"

With one last scream, the cultist was dragged by the chain into the black void. The hole closed with a howl and vanished into a trembling field of Shadows.

The faint green glow from the lamps on both sides fell on the now?empty graveyard path.

"That was a very special escape route," Duncan said, a little stunned by the sudden scene. After a moment, the corner of his mouth twitched. Something seemed to come back to him. "Wasn't this how Shirley and Dog ran off back then too…? But as I recall, she wasn't scared at all at the time."

Duncan frowned and stared in the direction where the cultist had vanished. He thought about it for a moment, but learned nothing, so he had to look away.

As he withdrew his gaze, the lamps on both sides, stained green, quickly returned to normal. The crisscrossing dim lights drew back through the darkness like retreating tendrils and gathered again at his feet.

A faint crackling sound reached Duncan’s ears.

Puzzled, he looked toward the sound, only to find it came from his own body. The soft crackles rose from all over him. Thin streams of black smoke seeped and curled out through the gaps in his clothes.

For a moment, Duncan was a bit confused, unsure what new problem this was. Then he yanked open his shirt at the chest and finally saw what was happening to this body.

His flesh was slowly turning into some kind of black, charred material. His shrunken skin was already full of gaps, and black smoke and ash rose from those gaps like smoke from a pile of burning wood.

If he had not undergone the “open your heart” Baptism at the very start, this strange and frightening sight would have shocked him badly. But by now, he was used to such weird and uncanny things, so he stayed very calm and even reached up to touch his neck.

The change seemed to begin at his throat—the place that had once held a symbiotic pact with a Abyssal Demon, where the chain had been attached.

Duncan at once thought of the jellyfish?shaped Abyssal Demon that had just burned itself up out of nowhere.

After he had taken this body, the “jellyfish” had gone on strike as if it could not bear the pressure. Now this cultist’s body was starting to collapse from the point where the chain of the symbiotic pact had been. Could it be that as

soon as the Demon in a symbiotic pact died, the body tied to it would fall apart as well?

Was this a trait of Annihilators?

Duncan jumped to the most likely guess and even thought of Shirley and Dog. Did those two have a similar link between them?

He could ask Shirley about it properly after he got back.

But first, he had to decide what to do right now.

Duncan looked helplessly at the body that was breaking down faster and faster. He could not help thinking of the shell he had used when he first climbed out of the coffin.

That body had fallen apart in the end too, even if for a different reason.

"…Why is it so hard to find a usable body?" he sighed, complaining about his bad luck. "Things went much more smoothly back in Pland."

He lifted his head and looked at the iron fence at the edge of his sight. Ahead was the graveyard gate. Past the gate lay a long stretch of cold, empty road. Beyond that empty stretch was the bright and bustling city.

The civilized world of Frostholm was right in front of him, but this collapsing body would struggle to make it that far. And even if he did drag himself into the city, with smoke leaking from him and bits of him falling off as he walked, he would never be able to quietly gather information. What he would do for sure was draw the attention of the patrolling Guardians at once.

He looked back at the graveyard.

There were plenty of bodies lying in the mortuary. But first, there was no way to know if the next one would also be poor quality. Second, opening the boxes took work.

This was blind?box shopping in the truest sense, and he had already gone through enough tonight.

After a brief weighing of options, Duncan raised his head and looked toward the lights at the other end of the path.

That should be the Warden’s cottage.

He remembered that two other cultists had disguised themselves as priests of the Death God and gone to that cottage with the Warden. The Warden might seem stubborn and unfriendly, but at least he was loyal to his duty.

cultists were not such decent people.

He started down the path toward the lights at the end.

…

There seemed to be some noise outside.

In the warm cottage of the Warden, the kettle on the stove was hissing. A gas lamp beside it filled the room with bright light. The Old Caretaker slowly arranged the jars and bottles on a wooden shelf. His trusty double? barreled shotgun hung from an iron hook beside the shelf.

Two men in black clothing watched the old man’s movements inside the cottage. One stood by the door. The other stood by the window.

But their attention was clearly not all on the Warden.

They were listening for movement from the graveyard gate, waiting for a certain signal.

They never got the coded message of “job done, withdraw.” Instead, they only heard some faint, strange noises drifting from the path outside.

The last unclear scream was especially unsettling.

“Did you hear something?”

The Old Caretaker suddenly stopped and looked up at the window, now dark and grimy with age. He tilted his head, listening to the sounds outside. In the night, there seemed to be nothing but the hollow murmur of the wind.

“Nothing,” the tall, broad?shouldered man at the door said at once when he heard the Warden. He felt uneasy too, but keeping the Warden honestly inside the house mattered more right now. “It was probably just crows.”

“Oh, crows,” the Old Caretaker muttered. “Crows are very annoying things. They steal your food and then stand proudly on a branch, laughing out loud at you… I hate thieves the most, and awful uninvited guests. Crows have both of those traits.”

The two men in black exchanged a confused look, feeling that this stubborn old man had suddenly started talking nonsense.

The Old Caretaker did not seem to notice their reaction. He just went on: “By the way, do you know why I followed that Lady’s advice and brought you two to my cottage?”

The shorter man in black seemed to grow vaguely wary and fixed his eyes on the Old Caretaker: “Why?”

The Old Caretaker finally found what he wanted among the many jars. As he twisted off the lid and sprinkled some crushed herbs into the stove, he said casually: “Because, usually, two people are easier to deal with than four.”

Chapter 294: Deathbed Hallucinations

A strong herbal scent filled the room.

No, it did not slowly spread. It appeared in their senses all at once—as if that thick scent had already filled the space long ago, but this fact had always been kept outside the Mortal Realm. Only now, as the old caretaker finished speaking, did this ever?present smell suddenly reveal its existence to the uninvited guests.

The two men in black reacted almost instantly. The shorter one jerked up his hand and pointed at the old caretaker standing by the stove. A low, hoarse cry came out of his throat, strangely like two voices overlapping. At the same time, the other man quickly pulled a few dirty paper slips from inside his coat and hurled them into the air.

The low, hoarse cry turned into a faint, visible ripple, like the shock wave from an explosion, and swept out in all directions from the old caretaker. The paper slips scattered with a rustling sound into countless shadowy fragments. The moment they hit the floor, they turned into a mass of black poisonous insects, snakes, and scorpions, which swarmed toward the stove while making a sickening scraping sound.

The old caretaker stayed hunched over and quietly watched those vicious attacks rush straight at him. He did not try to dodge at all.

The shock wave tore apart the shelf beside the stove. With a huge crash, every bottle and jar on it shattered. It also smashed the burning stove,

snuffing out the flames that had been sending up the thick herbal smoke. The black swarm of insects and scorpions crawled over the old man’s body and began to madly gnaw at his limbs and flesh.

The old caretaker was swallowed almost at once. His bent, withered body fell to the floor and turned into a mess of filthy blood and torn cloth.

It all happened in just a few seconds.

Only when the warden was lying on the ground and the still?warm ashes from the stove had spilled everywhere did the two men in black finally exchange a tense look.

The same confusion showed on both their faces.

“That’s it?” The tall, broad?shouldered man stared at the remains on the floor in disbelief and said to his companion: “Those graveyard wardens you always hear about in stories, all strange and dangerous… so they’re actually this easy to deal with? Or is this old guy just the weakest of the wardens?”

The shorter man did not relax at all. He still stared fixedly at the spot where the old caretaker had been standing, and at the same time swept his gaze around the cramped hut from the corner of his eye. His brows drew together bit by bit: “Strange… Do you smell that? The herbal scent is getting even stronger. It’s like someone is burning incense right beside us… No! We have to leave, now!”

The short man seemed to suddenly understand something. He rushed toward the wooden door of the hut at once. But when he reached out and shoved hard, he found the door did not move at all. It stayed as unmoving as a wall. The old, rotten?looking planks under his hands felt as solid as cast iron.

An old, grim voice rose in the hut: “One kind of Deathbed Hallucinations: you think you’re trapped in a room, the way out stands right in front of you,

you try to go through that way, but you can’t find how to open the door.”

The sudden voice made both men in black jump and also fed the fear that had already been rising in them. That kind of fear often turned into helpless anger. The short man gave up trying to force the door. He turned and shouted into the empty air: “I don’t care where you’re hiding!”

As soon as he spoke, layer after layer of ghostly ripples appeared around him. In those ripples, you could faintly see an ugly bird?shaped monster standing on his shoulder, stretching its neck and shrieking—that was a Death-Omen Bird demon.

The shriek of the Abyssal demon overlapped with the short man’s roar. A semi?transparent shock wave swept across the whole room in an instant!

The roar of splintering furniture and shattering ornaments rose together. In the blink of an eye, the warden’s small hut was left in ruins. Almost everything inside was smashed to pieces by the invisible wave. Only the space around the other man in black remained intact. The tall, broad man had raised a barrier around himself. While he blocked the leftover force of the wave, he quickly scanned the surroundings, trying to spot the twist of air that would show where the warden was hiding.

He had already guessed the warden’s trick—it was hallucination.

Some strong hallucinogen had been burned to cause visions.

The warden had used both extraordinary power and the herbs to hide himself and play tricks in the hut. But if his voice was still here, then he had to be nearby as well. As long as they swept through the whole house, that old bastard would have to show himself.

But he found nothing. The shock wave tore apart everything in the room and churned the air, yet it still did not force the warden out.

“Another kind of Deathbed Hallucinations: fear and anger are magnified. You feel a fierce helplessness. Sometimes you even feel as if you’re all? powerful, as if you’re about to overturn life and death itself—but that illusion usually fades in a very short moment, and then you fall into emptiness and an even greater terror…”

The old voice echoed through the hut. For some reason, the two men in black suddenly felt that it had gone thin and drifting. It sounded now near, now far, like light and shadow behind a curtain.

“A demon’s aura… Now I know who you are. You’re two Annihilators. Your disguise is good. You fooled my eyes, but not my intuition,” the old caretaker went on. “Why are you here? What are you trying to do?”

“The Holy Lord has given us courage and a pure essence!” the short man shouted. He forced his faith in the Abyssal Lord to press down his fear and slowly sank into a fanatical mood of sacrifice. “You stupid worldly replicas can gloat all you like! But you can only be proud for one moment!”

When he finished, the cultist suddenly pulled a pitch?black dagger from his coat and, without the slightest hesitation, stabbed it into his own heart!

“The Holy Lord gives me power beyond life and death!”

Knowing there was no hope and that he could not match a graveyard warden with his own strength, the cultist chose to offer his heart to the Abyssal Lord as a sacrificial rite. He meant to fully release the power he had gained from his symbiotic pact and make one last desperate try.

But the death he expected did not come.

He did not feel the sharp pain that should have followed when the dagger pierced his body.

He did not even feel his own heart.

The Annihilator raised his head in shock and looked at his companion. But he only saw that the other man was already lying on the floor. A huge hole gaped open in the man’s back, and all his blood had long since drained away.

In the last few seconds, as his vision darkened and his thoughts grew muddled, he recognized that terrible wound as the result of a double?barrel shotgun fired at close range—his companion had died long ago. The moment they stepped into the warden’s hut, the man had been shot from behind and killed by the old caretaker.

And what about him?

The short Annihilator lowered his head and saw that he was actually sitting in the chair in the center of the room.

A red?hot fire poker was driven cruelly through his chest and belly. Thin curls of smoke still rose where metal met flesh.

He remembered now. He had lost a brief but fierce struggle and had been killed with that poker—just ten seconds ago.

“So that’s it… a person can’t… die twice…”

The cultist muttered, his head lolled to the side, and he stopped breathing for good.

“The Deathbed Hallucinations are over. May your souls now scatter and vanish, with no blessing and no suffering.”

On the chair across from him, the gloomy old caretaker sat quietly, watching the cultist who had finally stopped breathing. He muttered in a flat voice, his face expressionless.

By his hand lay his trusty old double?barrel shotgun. All around him, traces of the brief struggle still marked the room.

The old man sat and panted a few times. Once some strength returned, he reached for the shotgun, pushed on his knee, and rose from the chair.

“I’m really getting useless… Two heretics left me in such a sorry state, and in the end I didn’t even manage to ask them anything,” the old caretaker grumbled. He stepped over the tall corpse on the floor and the other body that had fallen from the chair, then walked toward the wooden door with the shotgun in hand. “There are two more problems outside. I hope I’m not too late.”

He reached the door and was just about to open it when his hand suddenly stopped.

A strange aura was drawing near.

Sharp wariness flashed in the old man’s eyes. He tightened his grip on the shotgun, and in the next second a knocking sound came from the other side of the door.

Knock, knock, knock—

In the cold, silent winter night, the sudden knocking sounded almost shrill.

The old man did not answer. He simply stared hard at the dark, aged wooden door.

The knocking went on, very patient.

The thing outside was not a living person.

The old man narrowed his eyes. In his sight, a pale, dim outline stood outside the door. Twisted, chaotic light and shadow moved around it, but he still could not see what the thing really was.

It was not alive—but it was definitely not dead.

What was it?

“Please open the door. Thank you.” A polite voice spoke from outside.

The old caretaker slowly raised the shotgun and, through the door, aimed at the hazy outline beyond.

But before he could pull the trigger, a light click reached his ears.

The door… opened on its own.

A rush of dazzling, twisted starlight poured in.

Chapter 295: Departure

Oh no.

At the first glimpse of that warped radiance, the old caretaker realized that through his own carelessness he had fallen into extreme danger. On this freezing winter night, some unimaginable, unnameable being had come knocking at his door—and even worse, just a few minutes ago he had burned powerful incense to dig secrets from the souls of the cultists.

That incense was strong enough to build a Deathbed Illusion in the minds of the dead, shaped exactly as the caster desired. It could also greatly expand the caster’s range of perception and sharpen the mind. With its help, he had managed to pick out the aura of demons from the Abyssal Deep from the faintest ripples of thought in the two cultists.

But the side effect was that his Spirit Sight had been pushed to a higher level for a short time. Because of that, he now faced the visitor’s true form almost defenseless.

The brilliant, twisted starlight churned wildly outside the door, faintly sketching a huge, giant?like presence. A roar like ten thousand overlapping howls rampaged through his mind, every cry as if it would tear his soul apart. The old caretaker stood stiff as stone as he watched one strand of starlight reach toward him. At its tip, the light suddenly blossomed, and it seemed that countless eyes rolled and turned inside it.

Duncan looked at the old man holding the shotgun in front of him, then leaned to glance past the old man’s shoulder.

He saw the two bodies on the floor, already lifeless.

The cultists had been dealt with. This old man, who looked so frail, clearly had more strength than Duncan had expected.

“Looks like you’ve already taken care of the trouble. That’s good,” Duncan said with a smile and a small nod. “I came to help, actually. I was worried you might be in danger…”

As he spoke, he lowered his head to glance at his current state and quickly added: “Ah, I know I look a bit scary right now, and very suspicious. There are complicated reasons for that—the situation was urgent, so I had to borrow a body on short notice, and its quality isn’t very good. This body is slowly falling apart. But don’t worry, old mister, I’m not a bad person…”

In the booming roar inside his skull, there seemed to be fragments of human language mixed in. A few understandable words, tangled with a flood of vast knowledge, rushed through all his senses. In that invisible storm, the old caretaker faced the star?bright giant and realized the visitor was speaking to him.

The nameless being who had come in the winter night seemed to want to talk to him.

But he could not make out anything clearly.

There was only one thing he knew for sure—he was the graveyard guard.

He could not let such a suspicious being stay on land meant for the dead to rest.

The old man’s muscles were locked, but he still slowly raised the double? barrel shotgun in his hands. Under the crushing mental pressure and the wild disturbance in his thoughts, he aimed the barrels at that “individual” who felt as powerful as a deity.

“Leave,” he mumbled. Then he raised his voice: “Leave! Do not disturb them!”

Duncan frowned.

But he soon understood the old caretaker’s fierce reaction—after all, in his current state he really did not look like a good person.

His whole body was smoking. His skin was splitting inch by inch. Every move he made scattered half a pound of coal dust. The fact that the old man only pointed the gun at him and did not fire at once almost proved that the shotgun was probably empty…

“I should be going,” Duncan nodded and stepped half a pace back, not offended at all by the old man’s anger. “I just came to confirm how things were.”

He could feel that this body’s collapse had reached its limit. His spirit, projected from the Vanished, was slowly peeling away from this shell that was about to fall apart.

“This was my first visit today. Things were quite chaotic, and a lot of accidents happened,” he said to the old caretaker with a small smile. “But talking with you earlier was rather pleasant. I hope next time we can meet in a calmer, steadier setting. Goodbye.”

His spirit withdrew from the shell. The body, which had already died from demonic backlash during a symbiotic pact and had been crumbling ever since, finally gave out completely. Once Duncan stopped forcing it to hold together, it toppled backward, and the moment it hit the floor it shattered into a heap of dry, cracked charcoal.

The unnameable being suddenly left. It had really gone.

The old caretaker felt the huge pressure in his mind vanish at once. The maddening noise disappeared too. The twisted starlight before his eyes

faded in a blink, and a hollow ringing rose up to take its place. Wrapped in that constant ringing, he lifted his head and looked around. In the light of the gas lamps, the graveyard paths stretched away into the distance. On both sides of the paths, overlapping shadows seemed to hide countless twitching and jumping shapes. Near and far, the biers looked piled with twitching limbs and crawling shadows. Pairs of eyes blinked in the dark, each pair almost human yet not quite.

He shut his eyes tightly and silently repeated the name of God of Death Bartok. A few seconds later, he opened them again.

The strange scene in his vision was still there, but it was slightly better than before. At least now he could see more of how the Mortal Realm ought to look. He could see the lines between the path and the biers.

It was an echo of madness—the good news was that it was not madness without end, and not madness that would last forever.

The old caretaker looked down the path and saw a pile of bizarre charcoal scattered by the roadside. Then he looked toward the distant bier, but he could barely tell what was really there.

The pale light of the World’s Wound shone on this world.

His long experience turned into a clear judgment. He did not know how long his madness would last. If he kept moving around in this state—his judgment weakened and his mind ready to worsen at any moment—it could only lead to unpredictable results. He was not even sure that, the next time he raised his gun, he would be aiming at the living instead of the dead.

The unnameable being had left. From the view of a Higher-Order Entity, it had done no harm to this place at all. That meant it might be some sort of friendly existence. So at least for a while, nothing else was likely to invade the graveyard.

Any further investigation would have to wait until the Sun rose.

After thinking for a moment, the old caretaker turned and went back into the hut. He quickly locked the door and, while fighting the dizzy spell and ringing in his ears, locked the windows as well. Trusting his memory, he picked out herbs and Holy Oil from among the blurred shadows and writhing things his eyes showed him, and sprinkled them in the four corners of the room. Only after he finished did he walk to the center of the room. He pushed the still?warm corpse off the chair and onto the floor, sat down himself, hung a Death God badge on his chest, held the double?barrel shotgun in his arms, and quietly waited for daylight.

…

In the captain’s cabin of the Vanished, Duncan let out a slow breath and glanced to his side.

AI was tilting its head as it studied him. Then it suddenly spoke: “Our warrior is fighting the enemy… The battle is going terribly for us!”

“Alice is fighting something again?” Duncan listened to the sounds outside. From the deck came faint clanging and the doll girl’s occasional exclamations, but that kind of noise had long since become part of daily life on the Vanished, so he did not pay it much attention. He only shook his head: “Let her be. She’ll quiet down after fighting for a while.”

He rolled his slightly stiff neck and lifted his head to look out the window.

Dawn had not yet come. The Boundless Sea was still wrapped in darkness.

At the far end of that darkness lay Frostholm.

This rushed trip to Frostholm had not gone well. He had not even found a body he could use for long, and in the end he had not managed to leave the graveyard at all.

Still, even if things had gone badly, his efforts had not been for nothing.

Duncan thought back over his time in the graveyard and sorted through the information he had gained.

The Annihilators who followed the Abyssal Lord—that was the part that most deserved attention.

Four cultists had disguised themselves as priests of the God of Death, sneaked into the graveyard during the strictest hours of curfew to steal a corpse, and even given up their lives for it… That was no small matter.

It was easy to foresee that, after sunrise, what had happened in the graveyard would come to the attention of the authority in Frostholm and the local church, and it would stir up at least a small wave among the church's guardians.

And of course, the "dead man" who had climbed out of a coffin would also draw the local church's eye.

That temporary body…

Duncan's brows slowly drew together.

That corpse clearly had something wrong with it. It was not only that four Annihilators had risked everything in the middle of the night to steal it. The real problem was the strange way it had later "broken apart."

Duncan looked down at his own hands.

He still remembered very clearly how that body had collapsed. This was not his first time using a corpse, but it was the first time he had seen such a bizarre disintegration. Back in the sewers of Pland, even that sacrificial victim with no heart had never shown anything this strange.

At the same time, Duncan recalled one line the cultist had let slip without thinking:

“This body is almost at its limit.”

Those Annihilators clearly knew something. They had already been expecting the body to fall apart.

Duncan raised his hand and slowly rubbed his chin.

While he guessed at the cultists’ goals, he also thought about something else.

Were these unusual things… somehow linked to that “friend of True Resurrection” that Morris had mentioned?

Chapter 296

Pland’s southeastern dock district held a beautiful white steam?turbine ship that was undergoing its final overhaul and inspection.

After a long period of mooring, the White Oak was finally ready to set out again. This time it was going to carry numerous commissioned goods from the city?state of Pland, sail along the central sea lane and the northern route, head all the way north, pass by Cold Harbor, and reach Frostholm.

It was not a short voyage, but for an exploration vessel specially modified and built for fast long?distance runs, a route that lay mostly within safe waters posed little challenge. Its powerful steam core would ensure surging thrust, and the newly refurbished shipboard Cathedral was also enough to anchor every crew member safely in the Sanctuary World.

Both the sailors busy on the pier and the sailors hurrying about on deck looked rather relaxed.

In the White Oak’s aft machinery compartment, the Chief Engineer and the assistant artificer were overseeing the sailors as they finished the last checks on the steam core.

This mighty machine was as large as a house and was fixed to the ship’s main supporting frame by a sturdy steel skeleton. It consisted of three spherical vessels arranged in a row along the ship’s length, wrapped in a web of complex pipes, valves, and linkage devices. An iron catwalk hung halfway up the three vessels so that sailors could inspect the steam core’s operation and carry out necessary maintenance.

At that moment several sailors were busy on that iron catwalk. They had opened the heavy hatches on the spherical vessels and taken out a few dim metal rods that had been completely spent. Then they fixed several new rods—pale gold, as thick as a forearm and nearly a meter long—into the slots inside the hatch doors, triggered the mechanism, and watched as the rods were carried into the centers of the vessels.

Those were catalytic media made of Boiling Gold. They were the source of the steam core's fierce power and one of the key safeguards for its stable running. Just like the priest's prayers and incense rituals near the steam pipes, the Boiling Gold media inside the core could, to some extent, repel certain malicious forces and keep the machine from suddenly "going mad" after long continuous operation.

The squeak of pulley blocks and hinges rang out again and again. Two of the sailors were handling things a bit roughly, and the burly, bald Chief Engineer immediately shouted: "Careful! Don't damage those Boiling Gold catalysts! Those things are as soft as breadsticks—break one and the captain will eat you alive!"

"If you mean the breadsticks Head Chef Finley bakes—then you should be worrying about the chutes and catches in the steam core instead!" A sailor on the catwalk laughed, but even while joking, his movements still grew more careful.

"Once we get to Frostholm, I have to suggest to the captain that we buy a batch of high?grade Boiling Gold catalysts locally—the Boiling Gold over there is as cheap as the stones on the ground," the assistant artificer muttered nearby. She looked to be in her thirties or forties, with arms as strong as any man's and work clothes stained with grease. "The Adventurer Association's supply channels are daylight robbery."

“That depends on whether the clients and the Church agree,” the Chief Engineer said as he shrugged. “Half the cargo holds on the White Oak are special ‘sealed vaults’. A lot of what we’re carrying this time is raw materials and semi?finished components for sacred relics ordered by the Church. That stuff is very sensitive. Every crate of supplies brought aboard has to match a strict manifest. The Gray Crow ran into trouble before because some idiot secretly brought a barrel of mead onto the ship. It loosened one of their sealed vaults, and two Shadows got out and killed half the people on board…”

“I know, so when the time comes I’m only going to give the captain a suggestion,” the assistant artificer waved her hand, then frowned slightly. “But speaking of the captain, he still hasn’t shown up. He usually isn’t late.”

“The captain will come,” the Chief Engineer said. He paused for a moment, then repeated, as if to stress it: “The captain will come—he hasn’t retired yet.”

…

“You really should retire,” his wife said. She leaned against the nearby doorframe with her arms folded, staring at him with a dark expression and the same sharp eyes she had in the old days. “Don’t wait until I have to go on board and drag you off by the ear before you realize how serious your condition is.”

Lawrence did not answer. He only faced the mirror and quietly straightened his captain’s uniform, then checked his neatly combed hair. He solemnly picked up the hat lying next to him, placed it on his head, and only then let out a soft breath.

“Thank you, Martha, but I have to go,” the old captain said in a low voice. “The White Oak is waiting at the Harbor.”

His wife watched him quietly with her gaze. The harsh words were gone, the constant nagging was gone. Only that long gaze remained, and silence.

After an unknown length of time, she finally sighed softly: “All right then. Be careful and come back early—and don’t run into any more weird things.”

“I hope not.” Lawrence sighed helplessly and turned away from the mirror.

“Did you bring everything?”

“Everything.”

“The house key and your charm amulet for going out?”

“I have them, I didn’t forget.”

“Take a small prayer book with you. It helps.”

“Got that too,” Lawrence said. He bent down, picked up the small suitcase by the door, and patted it. “And a few pages of handwritten prayers, plus a Sacred Candle I got from the great Cathedral.”

His wife opened her mouth, as if she still had something to say, but Lawrence turned around with a smile: “I’ve packed everything. I’m not old enough to be losing things yet.”

His wife fell silent for a moment and let out a slow breath: “Your medicine.”

Lawrence’s movements froze in place.

“Your medicine. Don’t forget it,” his wife repeated.

Lawrence’s lips trembled slightly twice. His gaze slowly shifted to the side.

On the small low table by the door, a brown glass bottle sat quietly. sunlight spilled across the bottle, and he could faintly see the clear texture of the

liquid inside.

After a long silence, Lawrence picked up the bottle of medicine. Several more seconds passed before he finally pulled out the little stopper.

He looked up at Martha and saw his wife still leaning against the doorframe, arms folded as she watched him—just like in his memories.

“Safe travels,” she mouthed.

“I’m heading out,” Lawrence answered in a soft voice. Then, following the psychiatrist’s instructions, he let a few drops of the medicine fall into his mouth.

The strong taste spread through his mouth, and his wife’s figure quietly faded away in the sunlight.

Lawrence silently pushed the stopper back into the bottle, then opened the small suitcase and tucked the remaining medicine into a spot where it would not get bumped. While he arranged his things, he muttered under his breath: “That psychiatrist is full of nonsense… This stuff is bitter as death. There’s no ‘herbal fragrance’ at all.”

The old captain, who had spent half his life drifting on the Boundless Sea, finished preparing all he needed for the trip. He let out a quiet sigh, picked up the suitcase, and stepped out of his home.

…

After finishing a full day’s work, Heidi finally got home before dusk. She pushed open the door, took off her coat, and the first thing she did after walking into the living room was flop onto a chair in a most unladylike way and let out a deep sigh.

Her mother was sitting by the warm fireplace, sorting through a few letters. When she heard her daughter come in, she turned her head slightly: “You’re

a grown young lady now. Try to watch your manners a little—a lady doesn't behave like that."

"Let the lady rest a bit. This lady has spent all day dealing with bizarre nightmares and rambling seafarers," Heidi said. She slumped in the chair and weakly waved a hand. "A ship had a mechanical failure out on the Boundless Sea and was stuck offshore for almost twice its planned time. Several sailors were carried off the ship trussed up like dumplings—it was a complete disaster."

She sighed at that, shook her head, and commented: "Making a living on the Boundless Sea really isn't easy."

Her mother looked up from the letters: "That does sound terrible. All the more reason you shouldn't be slumped there. Go upstairs and take a bath first, relax a little. The water's already heated."

"All right, fair point," Heidi muttered. She finally mustered the strength to get up from the chair and started toward the stairs, but then stopped, suddenly curious: "And those letters are…?"

"Water, power, gas, all kinds of bills—odds and ends," her mother said casually, her tone calm. "Your father used to handle this, but he's out at the moment, so I'm dealing with it."

"Right. I don't want anything to do with that stuff," Heidi said, waving her hand as she headed upstairs.

Her mother quietly watched her daughter go upstairs, then pulled her gaze back and let it slide over the letters in front of her.

Most of them really were bills.

But two of them were real letters—and one of those came from a place beyond ordinary people's imagination.

It was a letter from Morris, delivered this afternoon by a Messenger wreathed in green flames.

The letter carried a special spell from the God of Wisdom, to keep any outsider from peeking at its true contents.

The old woman smiled as she looked at the familiar handwriting:

"…We're on our way to Frostholm now. There's not much scenery to speak of along the way. Only the occasional small floe on the sea and the distant cold mist are a bit interesting…

"…Nina was working on her winter break homework in the dining room today, and a strange Shadow jumped out of her textbook. Everyone rushed to beat it up. It was quite lively…

"…Before lunch, the captain went fishing again—you know, for that kind of 'fish'. This time it struggled very fiercely. It was a thrilling scene. The captain said lively fish taste better, but honestly I couldn't tell the difference…"

The old woman smiled, set this letter aside for the moment, and picked up the other letter she had just opened.

This letter, however, came from Frostholm.

The sender was Brown Scott.

Chapter 297

Madam Mary, Morris's wife, stared at the envelope for a long time before taking up a letter opener from the side and carefully slitting it open.

A thin folded sheet of paper slid out of the envelope. Before unfolding it, Madam Mary first noticed the uneven marks pressed into the back of the sheet.

They were the traces of handwriting—someone had pressed so hard with the pen that the strokes were clearly ridged on the back.

The person who wrote this letter must have been in a state of extreme agitation.

Sitting by the fireplace, the old lady adjusted her posture slightly, put the letter she had already finished reading onto the small round table beside her, and glanced at the date stamp on the envelope from Frostholm in her hand.

The sending date on this letter was December 5th.

It had been mailed on the third day after the first letter—in just three short days, the already "deceased" Brown Scott had written this second letter.

Madam Mary unfolded the paper. A few lines of scrawled, tangled writing came into view—nothing like the elegant, neat script in the first letter that folklorist had sent her a few days earlier. In these few short lines, the page was filled with the writer's deep unease and terror:

"My friend, something… is wrong. I don't know how to explain it to you. I'm very confused right now, I can barely even think. My mind is being

disturbed by something, my memories… Don’t come to Frostholm! In any case, you must not come to Frostholm! Even if you later see other things I’ve written to you, see other kinds of invitations, you must not come to Frostholm!

“There’s a huge conspiracy here.

“Don’t come to Frostholm!”

There wasn’t even a signature at the end of the note, and even the stamp on the envelope had been stuck on crooked.

Madam Mary stared at those few messy lines, and she could almost picture it: a folklorist whose mind had already cracked under a terrible tear in his understanding, using the last of his reason to write down these words, then staggering out into Frostholm’s bitter wind and struggling to hand the letter over at the post office.

She slowly folded the paper again and slid it back into the envelope.

It was a disturbing letter. The whole affair was soaked in a dreadful atmosphere from beginning to end. Under normal circumstances, it would have been enough to send its recipient running to the Cathedral to seek refuge.

But Madam Mary’s gaze drifted instead to the small round table beside her, to the family letter from the Vanished lying there—

“…The Deep Sea spawn really do have a unique flavor, far fresher than ordinary fish. The captain has mastered a special cooking technique, and Anomaly 099—Miss Alice—has learned its essence. I might have to try it myself…”

The old woman quietly tossed the letter from Frostholm into the fireplace beside her and watched as it burned quickly in the bright flames, turning to ash.

“They’ve already left…”

She murmured softly, then rose, took ink, a steel pen, and writing paper from the nearby shelf, and began to write a letter—one that would be delivered to the antique shop in the Lower City.

…

Church staff in black coats were walking all over the cemetery, examining every trace that remained here. Every path, every coffin, every lamp post had been marked and sampled, in the hope of reconstructing what had happened in this place last night.

“Gatekeeper” Agatha, however, stayed inside the warden’s hut. Sitting opposite her was the gloomy, stooped old caretaker.

After an unknown amount of time, the young woman—her body bandaged over in most places—raised her head and glanced out the window. She saw the Sun already sinking, and a faint reddish glow was spreading across the sky over the whole city?state.

Evening was approaching. The Guardians she had brought had already been working in the cemetery for several hours, and the old caretaker in front of her had also sat in silence for several hours.

Strictly speaking, the old caretaker wasn’t only silent—he remained in a state of near total mental closure. He did not move, did not speak, did not respond to any outside stimulus. From the moment the Church Guardians received the report and arrived here, he had been sitting quietly in that chair, like a breathing statue of flesh and blood.

A guard in black pushed open the wooden door of the warden’s hut, came over to Agatha, and bent down to whisper a report. She nodded slightly: “Understood. Send the samples to the great Cathedral first. Keep the scene as it is. Tonight may be crucial—we need people to stand watch.”

The black?clad guard nodded and accepted the order, but before he left, he couldn’t help glancing at the old man sitting motionless in the chair. Seeing those turbid eyes, as if frozen in place, the young guard’s face showed clear unease: “How long is he… going to stay like this? Is he really going to be all right?”

“It’s a protective mental shutdown. He’s using it to fight off and clear out the corruption in himself—and maybe to protect us as well,” Agatha said quietly. “The Gravekeeper must have come into contact last night with something far beyond imagination. It’s like he clawed his way back from the edge of madness… But don’t worry. He’s an experienced Warrior. He’s already managed to stabilize his condition. He’ll be fine.”

She paused, then added: “As for how long this state will last… that’s hard to say. It might end in the next second, or it might last until this time tomorrow. It depends on how long he was exposed to that terrible corruption.”

The guard thought for a moment and lifted his head to look out the window. Through the somewhat grimy glass, he could see the Church staff hurrying along the paths outside.

Then he drew his gaze back and looked at the two corpses in the hut—two intruders who had already been confirmed as Annihilators. They had obviously died at the old caretaker’s hands. Because the situation was still unclear, and in order to protect the scene, the bodies had been left where they fell.

They couldn’t be the reason for the old caretaker’s mental shutdown. Even the Demons behind them, in full runaway state, did not have that level of impact.

So what had done it? Some more powerful Abyssal Demon? A higher? ranking priest behind the Annihilators? Or something else altogether?

The black?clad guard voiced his questions, but Agatha only shook her head: “No. It’s probably something even more bizarre and dangerous.”

“Why are you so sure?” the guard asked without thinking.

“Because at the scene there were only traces left by a few heretic cultists, plus a pile of carcass fragments that appear to be from ‘Restless Ones’, with no remaining supernatural reaction at all,” Agatha said calmly. “No observable traces left behind means…”

“It means last night’s visitor didn’t do anything. It merely existed in this cemetery for a brief moment, and that alone was enough to push this old man to the edge of mental collapse.”

The old man’s voice suddenly sounded inside the hut, cutting across the exchange between the guard and the Gatekeeper. Agatha immediately turned toward the sound. Her usually blank face showed a faint smile at last: “You’ve come back to us. Good.”

“I wouldn’t dare say I’ve completely recovered,” the old caretaker said slowly. He was gradually steadying all the shifted perceptions that came with reopening his mind. He looked into Agatha’s eyes, consciously blocking out the leaping afterimages behind her. “But at least I can still tell which parts belong to the Mortal Realm and which parts belong to madness.”

“That’s enough,” Agatha nodded. “What happened yesterday?”

“The corpse you sent here suddenly grew agitated. It said a lot of things, clear?headed as if it were alive. Then four Annihilators came into the cemetery, wanting to take that Restless One away—they used the power of Abyssal Demons to disguise themselves. Their skills were polished; they were veteran Summoners. They slipped past my eyes, but not my instincts.

“I lured two of them here and killed them—that’s those two on the floor. I was just about to head back into the cemetery to deal with the other two when the unexpected happened.”

The old caretaker lifted his head and looked toward the door.

“An indescribable… Visitor came,” he said. “I looked into Its eyes for a while—it may have only been a few seconds. My sense of time was broken, so I can’t be sure.”

“An indescribable Visitor?” Agatha couldn’t help frowning. “Can you be a bit more specific?”

The old caretaker tried hard to recall.

Only a jumble of chaotic light and an overwhelming roar surfaced in his mind.

His hurried mental shutdown had erased the temporary corruption he had suffered, but it had also washed away some useful memories.

“No. All I remember are chaotic lights and noise,” the old caretaker shook his head. “And even if I could accurately describe what I saw, it wouldn’t mean anything to you. What I see isn’t necessarily real, and even if it is real, it isn’t necessarily the same reality other people see. As humans, our ways of perceiving things are far too limited.”

“All right, then that’s our whole answer,” Agatha nodded. “An indescribable Visitor came to the cemetery at the final stage, but didn’t take any active destructive actions… Are you sure you want to use the word ‘visit’ in the report? It’s a neutral term, even leaning friendly.”

“I’m sure,” the old caretaker replied calmly. “I spoke with It, though we barely managed to exchange anything at all. The Visitor did try to communicate. That’s a signal that’s neutral, leaning friendly.”

“Understood. I’ll record it that way,” Agatha nodded again. “And then? Anything else?”

“After the Visitor left, I vaguely saw that It left something behind… on the path by the door,” the old caretaker said, thinking as he spoke. “But I couldn’t make it out. My vision was already badly damaged by then, and my cognition was in chaos. I’m not sure…”

“If you mean a pile of remains burned up by backlash from Abyssal Demons, we’ve found it,” Agatha interrupted calmly. “If we’re right, that should be the Visitor’s… ‘vessel’.”

Chapter 298: PTSD

Outside the caretaker's hut, on the path leading to the mortuary, the heap of charcoal that barely kept a human shape still lay where it had fallen. Several Church Guardians were preparing to move the remains into a wooden crate, but when they saw the Gatekeeper and the graveyard's caretaker appear, they stopped what they were doing.

Gatekeeper Agatha pointed at the charred remains and said: "The one you saw yesterday should be him. Of course, what is left here now is only a shell. The 'Visitor' who once occupied this shell has indeed left."

The old caretaker walked up to the remains and bent his head to examine them for a moment, his brow slowly tightening: "He was…"

"If I'm not mistaken, he was one of the four cultists who disguised themselves as priests last night," Agatha said calmly. "This shell died from the backlash of a symbiotic pact with a Abyssal demon."

The old caretaker fell silent, his face severe. He seemed to be thinking about something. Two minutes later he suddenly looked up and said: "The body you sent last night…"

Agatha nodded and raised her hand to point in another direction: "Over here. But its condition… is even stranger."

Led by the Gatekeeper, the old caretaker came to an open patch at the edge of the mortuary grounds. This was where they stored processed "samples" and other key evidence that would be sent back to the great Cathedral.

The old caretaker stared in shock at what Agatha pointed out to him.

It was a heap of glass jars of various sizes.

“You mean… this is the corpse you sent yesterday? The ‘Restless One’ who chatted with me in the coffin for half the night yesterday?”

The old man stared at the pile of jars for a long time before he finally could not help turning suspiciously to Agatha. “Just one night ago, he was still lively enough to knock on the coffin lid!”

“Yes. But when the Guardians found this pile of stuff, all we could do was use shovels to gather it up and pack as much as we could into jars. Only the outline it still kept at the time and the spot where it was lying can prove that this really is the dead we sent to the graveyard last night,” Agatha said, shaking her head. “As you can see, it is a semi-solid… sludge, with only faint traces of biological tissue left. And even those last traces are quickly transforming into more sludge as time passes.”

She paused and pointed at one of the largest jars.

“There used to be a few bones in here. Now there is only this strange, sticky substance.”

The old caretaker frowned and stared hard at the bizarre matter inside the glass jars.

It had no trace of organic structure left. It was dark red mixed with black and gray, like silt from the bottom of a river.

If he did not know that the Gatekeeper would not lie to him, he would never have been able to connect this stuff with the Restless One who had babbled in his coffin yesterday.

“All right, the dead turned into sludge. Strange things always like to come in batches,” the old caretaker finally sighed. “But now that it’s come to this,

how am I supposed to explain it to this dead's family? They'll come to the graveyard to say goodbye to their kin, and I'll have to tell them that yesterday a few Annihilators sneaked in to make trouble, and something like a Subspace shadow showed up, so somehow their family member turned into a few jars of liquid?"

"Oh, you don't have to worry about that. Their family won't be coming to trouble you," Agatha said expressionlessly, shaking her head. "They have already finished the farewell ritual at Cemetery No. 4 next door. The miner who fell into the well will be sent into the furnace on schedule."

The old caretaker blinked, and his expression suddenly turned serious: "You forged a body to deceive the dead's family?"

"We haven't sunk that low," Agatha said calmly.

"Then…"

"We found another body. At noon today, we discovered a worker who had fallen to his death in that pump shaft. He was identical to the body we sent here last night."

The old caretaker stared, his expression going stiff.

After a long moment, he finally came back to himself and instinctively turned his head toward the nearby platform, where the simple coffin they had delivered to the graveyard last night still rested.

Then he looked back at the sample area, at the heap of glass jars that were terrifying to look at.

"…In the name of the God of Death, what on earth did you send here yesterday?"

"We will investigate," Agatha said. Her face rarely changed, but now it looked more serious than usual. "The only thing we can be sure of now is

that the body sent to Cemetery No. 4 should be the ‘real’ one. It showed no agitation and did not collapse or dissolve. The corpse we sent here yesterday… was tampered with by extraordinary power.”

The old caretaker did not speak for a while. He just looked troubled. At that moment, a black?clad Church guard came down another path and walked straight up to Agatha.

The guard gave Agatha a quick, low?voiced report, then handed her a thick piece of card.

Agatha glanced at what was on the card. Her expression did not change. She just nodded slightly: “Understood.”

“What happened?” the old caretaker asked casually.

“Do you remember there were four heretics who entered your graveyard yesterday?” Agatha raised her head and handed the card to the old man. “You took care of two. One turned into charcoal outside your hut. Now we have found the whereabouts of the last Annihilator.”

The old caretaker took the card and saw that it was a photograph.

On some concrete ground somewhere lay a heap of remains in which one could only vaguely make out a human shape. The remains were clearly charred—just like the pile of charcoal at the door of the caretaker’s hut.

Obviously, it was the backlash after a symbiotic pact with a Abyssal demon was severed.

“It was that woman…” The old caretaker frowned and looked up at Agatha. “She is dead? How did she die? Where?”

“Two blocks away. In full view of everyone, this pile of remains suddenly dropped into the middle of a crossroads,” Agatha said. “A Death-Omen Bird demon also appeared at the same time, clearly already in a runaway state.

That demon lasted less than a few seconds in the Mortal Realm before it collapsed and vanished. The bystanders at the scene called the constables."

The old caretaker thought for a moment and shook his head lightly: "I'm not an expert in this field. Just tell me what you think."

"My view is that this heretic probably also saw the 'Visitor' you met last night. The eyes of Abyssal demons find it easier to see the 'truth', so her Death-Omen Bird went insane and, in its madness, dragged its master down into the depths of the Abyssal Deep," Agatha analyzed calmly. "Judging from the remains, this heretic was torn apart by other Abyssal demons before the backlash from the symbiotic pact killed her. That is the typical outcome of falling into the depths of the Abyssal Deep without protection."

The Gatekeeper finished speaking calmly and let out a soft breath.

She fixed the old caretaker with her gaze.

"I feel… that something is turning its gaze on our city. The days ahead may not be peaceful."

…

Duncan arrived at the restaurant before dusk.

He did not know when it had started, but somehow the restaurant had become the place where the crew gathered in their spare time.

As soon as Duncan entered, he saw Morris marking Nina's homework, while Nina sat at another table not far away, supervising Shirley, Dog, and Alice as they spelled words.

Vanna sat near the restaurant window, carefully reading a Church book.

The atmosphere looked rather good.

Duncan walked straight over to Morris and casually handed him a letter: “A letter from your wife.”

“From Mary?” Morris put down his pen, looking a little surprised at the letter the captain handed over. He took out the small letter opener he always carried and opened the envelope while muttering: “I wrote in my letter that there was no need to hurry to reply.”

“Anyway, the ‘postage stamp’ only costs a few fries,” Duncan said with a smile. “See what it says. Maybe it’s something urgent.”

Morris nodded, took out the letter, and skimmed it quickly. As expected, he frowned without thinking.

“What does it say?” Duncan asked, curious, then added: “If it’s personal, you don’t have to tell me.”

“…The second letter from Brown Scott has arrived. It was sent only three days after the first one,” Morris did not hide it, though his tone sounded odd. “His mental state in the letter was clearly not right. Mary was worried that the letter carried something unclean, so she burned the original, but she repeated what it said. Brown was extremely anxious and urged me not to go near Frostholm.”

“…It seems your friend sensed a bit of the truth,” Duncan said thoughtfully. “Unfortunately, when I went to investigate Frostholm, it did not go very smoothly, and I wasn’t able to find out anything about your friend.”

“Ah? You went to Frostholm to investigate?” Morris was startled and couldn’t help crying out. “When did you go?”

“Just last night,” Duncan did not hide it. After all, everyone here was his own people. “I borrowed a body. It’s just a pity I couldn’t find out much. It wasn’t this troublesome last time in Pland.”

As soon as he finished speaking, he suddenly heard a soft thump from not far away.

Duncan and Morris looked toward the sound at the same time and saw that the book in Vanna’s hands had fallen to the floor.

Vanna the inquisitor had a rather odd look on her face.

Morris asked worriedly: “…Vanna, are you all right?”

“She is fine,” Duncan waved a hand and answered for Vanna. “She just has a bit of PTSD.”

Chapter 299: Undying Amusements

The captain often came out with strange phrases whose meanings were obscure and whose word?making was wild, but the crew of the Vanished usually took it in stride.

After all, there was an even more baffling pigeon on board. The captain and the pigeon always communicated smoothly, which proved that the bizarre words were not the captain’s problem.

The problem lay with the mortals, whose limited experience made it hard for them to understand.

In any case, anything they could not understand, they simply treated as a Subspace dialect.

Morris did not ask what “PTSD” meant. He just silently digested the information the captain had revealed. Duncan did not hold back and told them about his experience in the graveyard the previous night.

He mainly wanted to hear the opinions of the “professionals”.

Duncan’s story quickly drew the attention of the others in the restaurant. Nina was the first to come over, followed by Shirley, Alice, and Dog. In the end, even Vanna, who had been sitting quietly by herself, could not resist her curiosity and drifted over to the long table to listen in.

“Annihilators…”

Once Duncan finished, the first to frown was, of course, the most knowledgeable, Morris. “Why would they be interested in corpses…”

“Annihilators aren’t supposed to be interested in corpses?” Duncan asked curiously.

“They’re not necromancers,” Morris said, shaking his head. “Annihilators follow the Abyssal Lord. They study knowledge about demons and summoning. They have no interest in the flesh and blood of the mortal world. Not just no interest—really, you could say they despise and loathe it. They are convinced that mortal flesh is weak and filthy, and that the demons in the depths of the Abyssal Deep and the Abyssal Lord are the ‘primordial form’ that truly possesses pure sanctity. How would a bunch of heretics like that end up stealing corpses from a graveyard?”

Listening to the old scholar’s explanation, Duncan also frowned.

Annihilators despised the flesh and blood of this world and followed “beings in the Abyssal Deep that possessed pure sanctity”? They even believed that Abyssal demons and the Abyssal Lord had that “pure sanctity”?

Although he had known from the start that the cultists in this world each believed in something more twisted than the last, the Annihilators’ determination to challenge the limit of aesthetics was a bit too twisted even for them!

Duncan couldn’t help looking toward Dog beside the table. Shirley had dragged the creature over here. Now it lay on the floor, holding a vocabulary book in its two paws and studying it intently, its ugly skull of bare bone bobbing back and forth.

Noticing the captain’s gaze, Dog jerked its head up at once, its fierce bones crackling all over.

“Pure? Sacred?” Duncan looked at the Abyssal Hound with a strange expression. “Even the primordial form of life?”

Dog froze: “…Huh? What?”

“I can’t imagine it,” Duncan shook his head. “The world those Annihilators see must be completely different from that of ordinary people.”

He was just speaking offhand, but Shirley reacted at once: “Who knows how their brains grow. I’m not an Annihilator.”

“No one said you were,” Duncan said mildly.

“Tsk, tsk. I don’t know about anything else, but that woman cultist who ran off is definitely dead by now,” Shirley smacked her lips and added: “dead without even a complete corpse left.”

Duncan had not really thought about what might have happened to the cultist who ran. Hearing Shirley’s words, he was taken aback: “Why do you say that?”

“She was dragged into the deep sea of the Abyssal Deep by her own symbiotic pact demon,” Shirley explained casually. “Annihilators, tsk. No matter how much those idiots worship the Abyssal Lord, no matter how tightly they tie Abyssal demons to themselves, once they go into the true depths of the Abyssal Deep, they’re still treated as humans. Those uncontrollable demons only recognize auras. They’ll tear her to pieces.”

“Other Abyssal demons will tear her apart?” Duncan muttered. Then he suddenly remembered something. “Wait, I remember you and Dog once ran away using a similar method. You jumped into a rift leading to the Abyssal Deep right in front of me.”

At the mention of that glorious escape, Shirley’s expression also turned a bit odd, but she quickly waved it off: “That was different. When Dog takes me running, it does everything it can to protect me. It tries to muddle my aura, and if it really can’t, it starts a big fight with the other Abyssal demons. So every time we use that trick to run, it ends up covered in injuries.

“Other Abyssal demons are a different story. Like the one you just mentioned, it won’t protect its master. Right, Dog?”

“That’s a Death-Omen Bird,” Dog lifted its head and answered Shirley, glancing carefully at Duncan as it spoke. “Ordinary Abyssal demons really won’t actively protect their masters. They have no ‘heart’ at all. They only act together with Annihilators because the symbiotic pact binds them. Once they reach the deep sea of the Abyssal Deep, they go into runaway state at once. That cultist is doomed.”

“So that’s how it is.” Duncan rubbed his chin and muttered thoughtfully: “No wonder that fellow looked so reluctant when she was dragged in…”

Just then, Vanna, who had been silent on the side, finally could not hold back. She moved a little closer to the long table: “Those heretics… other than trying to lead you out of the graveyard, did they do anything else?”

Duncan looked up at Vanna, and she hurried to add: “It’s probably professional habit. I’m very concerned about those heretics’ goals. Like Mr. Morris just said, normal Annihilators have no interest in mortal flesh, which makes those cultists who appeared in the graveyard even more suspicious.”

“Now that you mention it, you do remind me of something,” Duncan said, rubbing his chin thoughtfully. “Not long after the body I was occupying left the coffin, it began to ‘fall apart’ in a very strange way. The skin and muscle cracked and crumbled off like dried mud. Those cultists seemed to have expected it.”

Vanna frowned slightly. She thought for a long time before something occurred to her: “So the key is the shell you were occupying at the time.”

“Do you mean…”

“Annihilators have no interest in mortal flesh. But what if that wasn’t ‘flesh from the mortal world’?” Vanna raised her head and looked Duncan in the

eyes. “In fact, it might not have been ‘flesh’ at all.”

Listening to Vanna’s analysis, Duncan looked thoughtful: “Oh… then this is getting interesting.”

…

After a long absence, the Sea Mist finally returned to her home port.

At the edge of the secret island shrouded in pack ice, turbulent currents, and mist, the proud bow of an ironclad warship lay moored steadily at the end of the pier. Undying sailors bustled about in the cold wind and thin fog. Some checked the condition of the ship. Others counted cargo or directed the cranes on shore as they hoisted heavy crates from the hold to the dock.

The Sea Mist had returned from the warm Central Seas. This time she brought back no news of victory, but she did bring gifts and specialties from afar: fine wine and souvenirs that Pland’s authority had given to the “Sea Mist Venture Company”, along with tobacco, cloth, and handicrafts the captain had bought with his own money. For a cold, shut?in hidden island, such things were treasures.

Although the Undying had already left the world of the living, they still had their own personalities and emotions. They also needed a life of a certain quality. They needed entertainment and pleasures, and in some ways they needed such things even more than the living did.

Their souls always felt cold and hollow, so they needed the warm creations of the civilized world all the more to fill those empty spaces.

First Mate Aiden stood at the edge of the deck, carefully stuffing fine tobacco from Pland into an old?fashioned short?stemmed pipe. He lit it with a lighter, clamped the mouthpiece between his teeth, and took a deep, satisfied draw.

Then he held his breath and gave a little push.

A hazy cloud of smoke seeped out from his crew uniform's collar, cuffs, and pocket seams on his chest, shrouding his entire upper body in white smoke.

Aiden turned his neck, glanced at the smoke around him, then pulled open his collar and took a look inside.

The bullet hole in his chest was still curling with thin wisps of smoke.

"Warm tobacco can fill the emptiness in the soul. But the holes in the body are another matter, aren't they."

A hoarse, dark voice suddenly came from behind him. Aiden turned and saw a pale, withered old man standing at the edge of the deck. The old man wore a priest's robe. One side of his skull was caved in, and the half of his body on that side looked as if it had been soaked in seawater.

It was Will, the Sea Mist's shipboard priest.

After muttering, the old priest raised a small bottle to his mouth and took a swig.

Thin trickles of liquor leaked from the cracked side of his cheek where his skull had caved in.

Aiden watched the old priest for a moment, then suddenly said: "Want me to teach you a trick? You could make that bottle last for days…"

"Tricks don't help," the old priest shook his head. "Mostly it's just disgusting, and by the third time it starts to taste sour."

Aiden shrugged, raised the pipe, and took another deep drag. He held his breath again, and once more his whole body was wrapped in smoke.

"Being Undying isn't so bad, really. I couldn't play like this when I was alive."

“…It’s nice to have such an easy heart,” the old priest couldn’t help sighing.

Chapter 300: Days on the Vanished

Aiden returned to the bridge. Tyrian was waiting for him there.

“The unloading went smoothly. In about an hour we can finish moving everything from the cargo hold to the Harbor warehouses,” the bald First Mate reported in high spirits. Every fold in his clothes still gave off a strong smell of tobacco. “The sailors who stayed on the island really like those ‘local specialties’ you brought back.”

“There will be a gathering tonight. Join us if you feel like it,” Tyrian said casually. Then he could not help looking at Aiden a few more times. He frowned and twitched his nose. “Did you smoke so much you set yourself on fire?”

“…Maybe a bit too much,” Aiden said, touching the tip of his nose in embarrassment. “Tobacco from Pland is always… hard to put down.”

“Try to watch it. Right now you smell like a piece of bacon,” Tyrian shook his head and gave the reminder, then stopped paying attention to that matter. He changed the topic. “Lately I often hear the sailors talking about Frostholm.”

“The news has already spread,” Aiden’s face grew a little more serious when he heard the captain’s words. “The dead coming back to life. No matter where the rumor started, what it says is enough to get the sailors talking. After all, everyone here is Undying.”

“Undying…” Tyrian repeated the word softly. “So, is everyone hoping to really live again?”

“To be honest, anyone with a bit of sense knows that is impossible,” Aiden shrugged. “An ordinary person might still like to imagine that kind of thing, but the more Undying a person is, the more they know that True Resurrection can only be a rumor. Death God Bartok is real. His gate only lets people go in, never out.

“And we only stay in the mortal world as so-called ‘Undying’ because our souls have already been twisted and changed, so we can no longer pass through that gate. Everyone understands very well where the boundary between life and death lies. After all, when we were all near death back then, we each wandered in front of that gate.”

Tyrian nodded lightly. He thought for a moment before speaking again. “Then why is this topic causing so much discussion?”

“Because real True Resurrection will never appear, everyone is guessing whether those so-called revenants are actually all… ‘living dead’,” Aiden grinned. “You know, most city-states do not like living dead, and Frostholm dislikes them more than most. They even treat them as ‘the curse on the outer sea’.

“Strictly speaking, we should not put the debts from half a century ago on the heads of the people of Frostholm today, but everyone still likes watching the authorities of that city-state run around in a panic.”

Tyrian raised an eyebrow. “Watching for fun? If this really has something to do with the old Abyssal Trench Project, it is more than just fun.”

“You are right, and I understand that,” Aiden said. “But for now, most ordinary sailors just want to enjoy the show first. Anyway, the first unlucky ones are the people of Frostholm. When the fun gets too big, they will think about other things. That is just how Undying think, especially when Frostholm is involved.”

Tyrian stared at Aiden in silence. After a while he could only wave a hand helplessly.

“…True Resurrection would mean passing through Bartok’s gate and then coming back out, and Frostholm’s main faith is the God of Death,” he said, with a serious face, instead of arguing more about whether it was right to hope the trouble got bigger. “In theory, in Frostholm, the rules of life and death should be even tighter and more stable. Now there are rumors spreading there about the return of the dead. That is very wrong.

“I am more inclined to think that some other kind of supernatural power is behind this.”

“Then we will have to see how the quiet Cathedral over there reacts,” Aiden said. “I heard the current Gatekeeper of the Cathedral is a new recruit named Agatha, a young lady without much experience. I do not know if she can handle this kind of trouble.”

Tyrian did not answer. For some reason, he suddenly thought of another young person, someone who had shown powerful strength and could calmly negotiate several times with his terrifying Father, a high-ranking priest.

Pland’s Inquisitor Vanna.

If it were that Inquisitor, who was strong enough to be a little frightening… dealing with a few small troubles about True Resurrection would probably not be a problem at all.

…

A slightly fishy, salty wind blew against her face, carrying a chill that the Central Seas never had.

Vanna sat on a wooden barrel near the rail and looked up at the endless sea in the distance. At the far edge of her vision a thin mist spread, and it seemed there were faint, blurry icebergs hidden deep inside the fog.

The Vanished had already entered the Frost Sea. They were now very, very far from Pland.

The young Inquisitor lowered her head again and kept carving the piece of wood with a small knife.

She was using Sea-Breath Wood to carve a new wave charm amulet.

Life on the Vanished was actually far better than she had first imagined. None of those frightening or strange, twisted things had happened. There was a normal schedule, decent food, clean and private living space, and noisy but rather interesting fellow crew members. From some angles, the living conditions on the Vanished were even better than those on normal ocean-going ships.

Because they had AI, the “Messenger”, the ship could always get fresh ingredients. Because there were many “living” facilities on board, the Vanished almost never suffered the kind of trouble that came from equipment breaking down. But the greatest advantage of this ship was not even that.

Its greatest advantage was… safety.

Yes, safety. It was hard to believe, but after living here for a few days, Vanna finally accepted this unbelievable truth of the Mortal Realm: there was no ship in the world safer than this terrifying ghost ship.

Because Captain Duncan was here, even Intruders from Subspace did not dare come to this ship and make trouble.

On the Vanished, people could freely talk about Subspace. They could freely read any book. Morris had asked AI to bring a big pile of folklore and history books from Pland. Once he began reading, he could sit there for most of the day.

To hurry on their way, sometimes the captain even had the Vanished sink into the Spirit Realm and race through those dark, terrifying Anomaly seas at full speed.

No Shadows from the deep layers ever appeared. Even if something really popped out, it only became part of the crew's daily fun.

Or an extra dish at dinner.

All in all, life on the Vanished was actually not bad.

But she still needed some time to get used to it.

The small knife cut deep grooves into the wood. Shavings fell bit by bit, and her slightly restless heart slowly calmed down.

Footsteps came from behind. A lively voice suddenly sounded beside her. "Miss Vanna, what are you doing?"

Vanna looked up. Nina was staring curiously at the half-finished charm amulet in her hand and at the few finished charm amulets placed on another wooden barrel.

"These are charm amulets offered to the storm Goddess Gamona," Vanna said with a smile. She knew this girl in front of her, who looked so ordinary, had a shocking identity, but after spending a few days together she no longer felt surprised by any crew member's background. "Throwing a Sea-Breath Wood charm amulet into the sea counts as making an offering to the Goddess."

"Oh!" Nina nodded in sudden understanding and looked at the charm amulets on the barrel with wide, amazed eyes. "I think I heard about this in school before, but this is the first time I have seen one. You made so many!"

"Actually…" Vanna started to speak, then hesitated a little. She looked at the bright sparkle in Nina's eyes, then slowly lifted the lid of the barrel.

“Not just these few.”

Nina froze for a moment. She leaned over, peeked into the barrel, and stayed frozen.

After a while she lifted her head and looked at the Inquisitor in front of her.

“Miss Vanna… are you super bored on the ship?”

“Not really,” Vanna said, her expression a little awkward. She also felt that carving a whole barrel of charm amulets in just a few days was a bit much. “I just… might need a little more time to adjust.”

“Oh.”

Nina nodded, then moved to the side of the barrel. She squatted down and started staring at it in a daze.

No one knew what she was thinking about.

Vanna put down a new wave charm amulet and quietly put away the knife.

“Miss Vanna, you are not carving anymore?” Nina asked.

“…I have run out of material.”

“Then ask AI to bring some more?”

“That will not be necessary…” Vanna waved an embarrassed hand. She was just about to say more when a strange, low rumbling sound suddenly came from the direction of the sea and cut her off.

It sounded as if something was moving under the water and rushing upward with a mass of bubbles.

At almost the same time, a creaking sound came from the direction of the Vanished’s mast. The next second, Vanna saw the spirit form sails above the

ghost ship adjust their angle a little. The huge hull followed, changing its posture and course.

Nina ran to the rail, eyes wide as she stared at the distant sea. She suddenly pointed and shouted: “Look, look! Miss Vanna! Something came out!”

Vanna followed the direction of Nina’s finger.

She saw a large patch of foaming waves. The chaotic, uneven water swelled up like a small hill in the distance, and a huge shadow slowly rose within the foam and currents, coming up to the surface.

A high mast, a rusted bow and smokestack, a torn and broken deck…

It was a ship.

Chapter 301: Boarding the Ghost Ship

A ship had “risen” from the sea in a shocking way and now stood in front of Vanna and Nina.

The waves on the surface had not yet calmed. Layers of turbulent water spread outward with the rusted ship as their center. Seawater kept pouring down from its corroded smokestack and deck structures, making loud, harsh sounds. The ship rocked slightly between the waves. Slanting sunlight fell across its deck, spreading a strange, unreal color over it.

Nina stared with her mouth open. After a few seconds she finally reacted and began shouting. “Ah! A ship! A ship! A ship suddenly popped up!”

Then she suddenly turned to Vanna, speaking so fast her words almost ran together. “I am going to tell Uncle Duncan!”

Before her words even finished, the girl had already turned and rushed across the deck like a gust of wind, running toward the stern.

Vanna still stared hard at the strange ship that had suddenly risen from the sea. She studied its old, decayed marks and every detail on its hull.

She noticed a line of large letters on one side of the bow. The letters were badly covered by rust and grime, so they were very hard to read, but she still managed to sound them out.

“The Obsidian.”

The noise from this mysterious ship suddenly appearing on the sea was great. Of course Nina and Vanna were not the only ones who noticed it. In just a short time, the others who had been resting in their cabins came out and gathered on deck.

Morris, Shirley, Dog, and Alice all came in surprise to the bow, looking out at the strange ship in the distance and guessing where it had come from. Very soon, Duncan also followed Nina out onto the bow deck.

“Mr. Duncan,” Vanna said at once when she saw him, “there are no signs of living people on that ship. It might be a… ghost ship.”

Her expression looked a little strange when she said the words “ghost ship”.

“One of our own,” Duncan replied casually, then lifted his head to study the ghost ship that looked only about half the size of the Vanished. The first thing he noticed was the smokestack structure on its upper levels. “Looks like a steamship… can you guess its rough age and origin?”

“There is no need to guess,” Morris said from nearby. The old scholar gazed toward the distant sea with a complicated look in his eyes. “I saw its name. The Obsidian. A fast steam cutter, sunk six years ago off the coast of Frostholm.”

“Huh?” Shirley, who had been craning her neck, looked at the old gentleman in surprise. “Old gentleman, you know that ship?”

“Brown Scott had his accident on that ship,” Morris said, his voice a bit low. “But how… how did it suddenly appear here? And in this way…”

Alice listened to the others talking. She looked up at the Obsidian in the distance, then turned her head back to look at Morris and Duncan. After thinking hard for a bit, she finally asked, “Captain, is this normal? Will a sunken ship just float back up out of the sea?”

“Of course this is not normal,” Duncan gave the silly girl a look. “This is called a ghost ship. And I suspect it is not just a ghost ship.”

As he spoke, Goathead’s voice suddenly sounded in his mind. “Captain, should we fire two shots to test it? The cannons say that from this angle and distance they feel a bit hungry and cannot help wanting to throw a few shells over…”

“Tell them to hold it!” Duncan cut Goathead off without hesitation. He thought for a moment, then turned to the people beside him. “We have to go over there and see what is going on.”

“We are going… onto that ghost ship?” Shirley shrank her neck at once. “Is that not a bit reckless? I am not scared of other things, I am just afraid that ship will suddenly sink again. It popped up out of nowhere, after all…”

“AI will bring us back,” Duncan said, giving the young lady a calm look. “Of course, if you do not want to go, you can stay here. I am not forcing you.”

Shirley opened her mouth, but before she could speak, Dog broke the silence first. “We will go, we will go! Serving the captain is our duty! We would be happy to!”

Shirley froze, then began complaining silently to her partner. [Dog, can you please have some principles…]

[How is seeing the situation clearly and taking part in group activities not a principle?] Dog answered with confidence in the mental link. [The big boss is leading the team, so we do not have to worry about safety. Of course we should do our best to show what we can do…]

[What I mean is, can you leave the chance to hug the big thigh to me next time? You grab it every time…]

Dog thought for a while. […Shirley, can you please have some principles?]

Duncan did not care what Shirley and Dog were talking about while they stood there in a daze. He knew that when these two “people” went quiet, they must be whispering in the mental link again. Instead, he looked up at the others. “Are you coming along?”

“I am going!” Nina raised her hand first. She even looked a bit excited. “It is a ghost ship. I only heard about them in stories before. I have never seen one with my own eyes.”

“The Vanished is also a ghost ship,” Duncan had to remind the young lady, then looked at the others. “What about you?”

“There might be clues on that ship about what Brown did before his accident,” Morris nodded. “I will go with you.”

“I will go too,” Vanna said. “A ghost ship phenomenon is very likely connected to heretics or evil corruption. I have some experience with that.”

“I am not sure,” Alice said after thinking for a bit. She looked at Duncan. “But I want to stay with the captain.”

“Then we will all go. Treat it as seeing more of the world,” Duncan said casually. He waved toward the mast not far away, calling down the pigeon that had been sunning itself with closed eyes high above. “AI, take us over to that ghost ship.”

A ball of ghost-green flame suddenly rose from the Vanished. A moment later, a huge skeletal bird soared into the air and flew toward the Obsidian, which rocked gently on the waves in the distance.

The deck of the Vanished grew quiet.

The quiet lasted for a short while. Then the small boat hanging near the side of the Vanished began to creak sadly and sway.

It was a shuttle boat, normally used to quickly move people between two ships when they were close together on the sea.

Two coiled ropes lying along the edge of the deck began to rustle as they moved. They slid like snakes over to the shuttle boat and lifted their ends to pat its hull.

Goathead, who had stayed behind in the captain's cabin, of course sensed what was happening near the deck. It sighed softly and spoke to the old fellows it had worked with for a century. "Maybe you little boats should practice paddling around in the sea yourselves…"

The shuttle boat creaked even louder…

On the other side, AI did not land on the Obsidian right away. Under Duncan's command, she circled several times in the air over the ghost ship. Only after she roughly confirmed that there were no moving targets anywhere on the ship did she land on a section of deck that looked clean and stable.

ghostly green flame burst into the air, and Duncan's group stepped out of the fire.

A strong, dirty smell rushed into all their noses at once. It was the fishy stench of seawater, mixed with some other rotten odor that was hard to name.

Nina was the first to wrinkle her nose after stepping onto the deck. "Ugh… it smells awful up here…"

"Not every ghost ship is as clean and tidy as the Vanished, and not every one has unlimited fries," Duncan said to Nina with a smile. "If this ship really is the Obsidian from back then, it has been soaking in the Deep Sea for six years."

As he spoke, he looked around at this steamship that gave off an eerie feeling from every corner.

Rust, broken edges, mottled stains. It might once have been a pretty and advanced mechanical cutter, but now it was only a heap of dead steel and wood.

The strangest thing, though, was that as a ship that had just risen from the sea, there was no seawater to be seen here.

The deck was dry.

Even in many of the dents on the deck, those places that should easily hold pools of water, everything was dry.

Vanna had clearly noticed this too. She squatted and rubbed the ground with her fingers, frowning.

She still remembered the scene when this ship came up out of the sea. A huge amount of water had poured off the Obsidian, like endless waterfalls washing over every corner of the ship. Judging by common sense, there should not be a single dry place on this ship.

“Vanna,” Morris said, turning around after he had quickly checked the area around them. “Do you feel any trace of heretics or evil corruption?”

“…No,” Vanna said, slowly shaking her head with a frown. From the moment she had stepped onto the deck she had been watching for this, always feeling for any wave of supernatural power. “There is not the slightest supernatural aura. But that only makes it stranger. The dry deck is clearly not normal, and behind any abnormal phenomenon there should be some supernatural power at work.”

“Then it might be an supernatural power beyond what you can sense,” Duncan said casually, then started walking forward. “Anyway, if something

really is hiding on this ship, as long as we look around enough, it will show itself."

Nina quickly ran a few steps to catch up with her Uncle Duncan. "What if something really jumps out?"

Duncan stopped and turned back with a smile. "Then we try talking sense first…"

Chapter 302:

The deck of the Obsidian was small and easy to take in at a glance, so the group quickly finished searching the whole area and found nothing suspicious.

Apart from the places that should have been damp and full of puddles now being oddly dry, the Obsidian's deck looked no different from that of an ordinary wrecked ship. It was heavily rusted, uneven, and damaged in many spots, but overall it had not yet reached the point of total collapse.

After checking the deck, Duncan decided to go inside the ship and take a look.

They soon found a large door that led into the cabins.

It was a rust-covered iron door set into a white wall. The handle had rotted badly, and the lock had long since been ruined by seawater. The whole door was shut tight and clearly could not be opened by normal means.

Morris stepped forward to check the door, then gave up on opening it normally. He turned to the others and said: "We might have to use a bit of force."

"I'll do it," Vanna volunteered before anyone else could speak. "Everyone step back a little so you don't get hit by debris."

Shirley and Alice quickly did as they were told and backed far away. Duncan hardly moved. He only stepped aside two paces so his clothes would not get dirty, then watched Vanna with curiosity. He saw the sturdy

woman walk up to the big rusted door and then… casually knock on the door panel with her hand.

A sharp hum rang out, and the center of the iron door simply shattered into a gaping hole. The solid, heavy steel broke into countless fragments that flew in all directions, and dust billowed from the opening.

Then Vanna reached out and tugged at the edges of the hole a few times, tearing the remaining steel plates from the frame as if she were ripping paper. She tossed the pieces aside.

Shirley and Dog stared, dumbfounded, for a long moment before they finally blurted out together: "…What the hell, is she even human?"

Of course Vanna heard them. She turned her head and smiled: "I work out regularly."

Shirley's mouth twitched. She muttered under her breath: "This has nothing to do with working out anymore…"

Duncan also admired Vanna's simple and brutal solution. But he had already seen this fearless maiden fight her way through an entire city, so he did not react much. He only raised his head to look at the smoke-filled doorway and asked: "What is it like inside?"

Vanna waved a hand, waited for the dust to settle a little, then leaned in to look. Her expression immediately turned strange.

A few seconds later, she stepped back and turned to Duncan: "Inside… there's another door."

"Another door?" Duncan froze for a moment, then walked over in a few quick steps to see for himself. Sure enough, another rusted metal door stood right there, only a few meters behind the one they had just broken.

Yet the space between the two doors was not a corridor, nor a foyer, nor any kind of designed safety buffer. It was just an empty space, with no equipment or furnishings and no extra windows, only bare walls and a ceiling that, for some reason, looked crooked and skewed.

"…I am not sure if this is the Obsidian's normal layout," Morris said after coming over for a look. He shook his head. "Before this, I only knew of the ship. I had never seen it in person."

Duncan frowned slightly, then quickly nodded to Vanna: "Open that door too."

Vanna stepped forward at once and repeated the process, smashing the second door. Then she leaned in again, and turned back with a stunned look: "Inside… there's another door."

"Another one?!" Even Shirley was surprised this time. She forgot about keeping a safe distance and dragged Dog over. "Whoa… there really is another one?!"

Behind the second door was a third door, with the exact same layout and the same strange little "compartment" in between.

If there had only been a second door, they could still have explained it away as some special design of the Obsidian. But now a completely useless, senselessly eerie third door had appeared… It was hard to brush this off as just "an advanced design concept" for the ship.

"The structure of this ship is wrong," Duncan said. He looked back at the two doors behind them, his expression turning a bit more serious. "Whether it's normal or not, it should not have a layout like this… Vanna, open this door as well."

"Alright." Vanna did not hesitate. She stepped up and punched the third door. This time she stopped after opening a large hole and did not bother to

clear the remaining steel from the frame, because she could already see what was inside through the gap.

“Cap…tain,” she said, still not quite used to the title. Her expression turned even stranger than before. “It’s a wall inside.”

“A wall?!” Duncan’s eye twitched. He looked through the hole and saw exactly what Vanna had described.

There was indeed only a wall opposite the door, less than half a meter away. It was almost pressed right up against it. The space between the door and the wall was meaningless and too narrow to hold anything.

“How could a ship be designed like this?” Nina muttered in confusion. “Three doors, and behind them is just one wall… Then where are the cabins? How are we supposed to get into them?”

Duncan did not answer. He only looked quietly at this oddly structured “overlapped area”, his eyes thoughtful, as if something had occurred to him.

After a moment, he nodded to Vanna: “Keep opening it.”

Vanna stepped forward at once. She first kicked away the remaining lower half of the third door, then slammed her fist into the strange wall. A much larger hole appeared with a thunderous boom.

“It’s a corridor,” Vanna said after taking a look inside. She turned to the others as she spoke.

“Great,” Shirley breathed out in relief. “Finally something that looks normal…”

“It’s upside down,” Vanna went on before Shirley could finish. “The ceiling is under our feet, and the floor is over our heads.”

Shirley muttered: “…What the hell.”

As Vanna had said, behind the wall there was only an upside-down corridor. Just like the three repeating doors, there was nothing normal about the layout inside this ghost ship at all.

“This ship has been twisted…” Even a well-read scholar like Morris looked a bit lost now. He stared in disbelief at the corridor beyond the wall and muttered to himself: “What could have warped the Obsidian into something like this…”

“Think about it another way,” Duncan cut off the old scholar. “Is this really the Obsidian?”

Morris looked up sharply, staring at Duncan in shock: “You mean…”

“We are near Frostholm, and something terrible once happened in the Deep Sea beneath Frostholm,” Duncan said casually. He glanced at Alice, who was looking around curiously. “Do you remember what Tyrian said back then about the ‘Abyssal Trench Project’?”

“I remember, I remember,” Alice said, nodding quickly. “And a whole bunch of submersibles and so on…”

“It’s enough that you remember that much,” Duncan said as he pressed down on Alice’s head. “Stop nodding. You’re starting to wobble.”

Then he raised his hand and knocked on the wall beside him.

The metal bulkhead gave off a hollow thump under his knuckles.

“It looks normal on the outside, but inside it’s a complete mess. Crude imitation and copying, internal spaces stacked together in the wrong way. This should not be the real Obsidian, though it’s hard to say which ‘number’ Obsidian this one is.”

Alice had no idea how much of that she actually understood. She only drew out an “Ohhh” and nodded slowly in a very serious way. It was Vanna,

standing beside her, who reacted quickly: “But I remember you once said that back during the Abyssal Trench Project, only the crew members inside those rising submersibles were distorted during the copying process. The submersibles themselves were copied correctly. You guessed back then that this kind of error should be limited to people or other living beings…”

“Yes, it was limited to humans or other living bodies, at least it was like that half a century ago, when the Queen of Frostholm was still alive,” Duncan said slowly. “So the situation is clearly worse now. The copying is no longer limited to Submersible Three, and the distortions have spread to inanimate matter. Whatever lies in the Deep Sea under Frostholm has clearly started moving again after fifty years of silence, and its range and intensity are far beyond what they were half a century ago.”

Shirley blinked as she listened. Everyone on the Vanished had heard the story of the Abyssal Trench Project from the captain, so they all knew how strange and cursed it was. That made her mutter without thinking: “I… I’m starting to get nervous…”

“Think about it another way. The captain is the one investigating this. I don’t think we’re the ones who should be nervous,” Dog whispered too. “Stop scaring yourself. My heart rate is going up with yours.”

Shirley froze: “Dog, you have a heart?”

“I’m a demon with a heart!”

“A heart and ‘having heart’ aren’t the same thing. Isn’t your chest cavity empty?”

“…What if it isn’t? Maybe there’s something in there jumping around.”

“Want me to dig it open and check?”

“No way.”

Duncan paid no attention to the increasingly morbid whispers beside him. After making a quick guess about the ghost ship’s condition, he turned his attention back to the corridor, which might lead who knew where.

After a brief moment of thought, he stepped toward the large hole Vanna had made: “Let’s go in and see what’s going on.”

Chapter 303:

Duncan had Ai perched on his shoulder as he was the first to pass through the hole and step into the upside-down corridor. The others followed one after another behind him, and this time Vanna took the rear, in case of a sudden ambush.

The group moved carefully along the corridor. Everyone watched their surroundings at all times and studied every feature of the corridor as they went.

Once they entered the corridor, they did notice some details they had missed at the entrance.

The corridor was not just upside down. Distortion and strangeness were everywhere.

Doors of all kinds of mismatched sizes were set haphazardly into the walls on both sides, some upright, some upside down. round portholes appeared from time to time, but the other side of the glass was either a wall or yet another door or window. Strange geometric bulges jutted from the walls and floor, looking like pieces of rooms from somewhere else that had been fused into the corridor in the wrong way.

The inside of the Obsidian felt like the innards of a huge beast after a terrifying doctor had butchered and rearranged them. All its organs were twisted and piled together at random. Rooms overlapped, doors slanted, exits and entrances linked to this corridor, which seemed to be the main

passage, in utterly random ways. And at the far end of the corridor… who knew what might be lurking in the dimness.

The ghost ship was very quiet. Only the sound of their footsteps rang out as they struck the “floor” that should have been a ceiling. The sound echoed through the hull, and there seemed to be something else mixed into the echo.

Nina and Shirley looked somewhat nervous. Alice, on the other hand, seemed fine. It was not that the doll was brave; she simply lacked common sense. All her experience with ships and sailing came from the equally cursed and bizarre Vanished, so she did not think there was anything here worth fearing.

They walked on for who knew how long. The long corridor seemed to stretch endlessly into the dark, and the area ahead looked dimmer and dimmer. Duncan poked the pigeon on his shoulder: “Light.”

Ai let out a sharp cry at once: “Take up this battle axe of the Sun! Embrace the glory of combat!”

As the pigeon shouted, bright green flames rose over its body. The blazing fire quickly drove away the darkness in the corridor.

Vanna stared in shock at the scene and whispered to Morris in front of her: “This pigeon… can be used like this?”

Morris sounded very calm: “The captain does this all the time. When the pigeon is not with him, he uses himself as a light source.”

Vanna stared: “…?”

But this time, before she could once again lament the gap between the legendary Captain Duncan and the one in the Mortal Realm, a sudden noise cut off everyone’s movements.

“Thump, thump, thump…”

It sounded like a dull knocking, from behind a nearby door.

Everyone stopped at once. All eyes turned to where the sound had come from.

It was a blue door, with the words “Captain’s Cabin” written on it.

On a normal ship, the captain’s cabin could never be in a place like this. But on this ghost ship, where everything was already in chaos and all the cabin entrances were piled together at random, any door could appear anywhere.

“Thump, thump, thump…”

The knocking came again, louder than before and now a bit urgent.

It sounded as if a survivor of a shipwreck were hiding behind the door, and after hearing movement in the corridor, had started pounding on it in panic to call for help.

Vanna silently reached back to grip the greatsword on her back. Shirley lifted the black chain in her hand. Nina slipped behind Alice, and Alice raised her arms to cover her head.

With a blank face, Duncan walked up to the door.

The dull knocking continued without stopping.

But Duncan did not seem about to open the door. He only bent his fingers and knocked twice in return.

The knocking inside stopped at once, as if the one making the sound was taken aback. After a few seconds of silence, a hoarse, low voice suddenly broke it, coming from behind the blue door: “Is… someone out there?”

“Yes,” Duncan said calmly.

“Ah, that’s great! I am the captain of the Obsidian. I don’t know what has happened on the ship, but I am trapped,” the hoarse voice said at once. “Kind sir outside the door, what is your name? Could you help me open it?”

“Just call me Duncan,” Duncan said. At the same time, he pressed a hand down behind him to signal the others to stay calm. “Before I open the door, I want to confirm something, are you really the captain of the Obsidian?”

“Of course! My name is Cristo Barbelli. You can check my name and identification number at the Harbor Office. My papers are right here in the room,” the voice answered at once. “But… for some reason this damned door will not budge at all, and I really have no way to come out and prove my identity to you…”

“Next question,” Duncan said. He ignored the rambling behind the door and went on: “What year is it?”

“This year?” The voice inside clearly froze for a moment, probably thinking the question was odd, but still answered: “Why, it’s 1894, of course. Is there something wrong with that?”

Duncan glanced back at Morris, and the latter gave a slight nod.

1894. That was the year the Obsidian was lost at sea.

Thinking of that shipwreck, Morris suddenly stepped forward and asked: “Excuse me, Captain, do you know if there is a passenger named ‘Brown Scott’ on your ship?”

“A passenger?” The voice behind the blue door sounded a bit unsure. “I cannot remember the name of every passenger on board, but… are you talking about Brown Scott? Ah, I remember now, that one I do know. The folklorist? He is a man of some repute. I spoke with him several times. I recall he is a rather thin gentleman, with his hair and beard always neatly

kept. He has studied the funeral customs of various city-states, and he is very interested in the frozen seas north of Frostholm…”

Listening to the voice behind the door, Morris nodded slightly and said to Duncan in a low voice: “No discrepancy.”

“His mind is clear, his memory intact, and he can state his name accurately,” Vanna, who had been silent until now, suddenly said. “But that does not rule out an evil creature that has absorbed human memories and emotions and is using them to set a trap. Such things are not rare on ghost ships.”

“Oh, that does not really matter. As long as it truly has that captain’s memories, it’s enough,” Duncan said carelessly. “Monsters can talk reason first too. If reason does not work, we use physics. One way or another, it will understand.”

Vanna stared for a moment. “…That is true.”

Duncan put his hand on the blue wooden door’s handle.

“I’m going to open the door now, Mr. Barbelli,” he said to the person inside.

Then he turned the handle. Unlike the other completely rusted cabin doors they had seen, this one showed no signs of damage. As he turned it, he heard the soft click of the lock turning at once.

The door opened.

Under everyone’s slightly tense gaze, Duncan pushed the door open.

A twisted, upside-down room appeared before them.

All the walls were crooked, and the ceiling slanted as if it were about to collapse completely. The room’s original furnishings had been randomly fused into the nearby walls and floor, as if buried in wood and metal. Only

broken halves of tables and chairs stuck out here and there. On the wall facing the door there was an especially large hole, and beyond it was only darkness. It was impossible to tell where it led.

The twisted room itself was empty.

Duncan swept his gaze over the empty room, but the next second he heard Captain “Cristo Barbelli’s” voice coming again from behind the blue door: “Ah, did you open the door? I think I felt it move, but it still does not budge in my hand… Is something wrong with my senses or my perception? Could you help me? I may have been stuck out at sea for too long and started to show some bad symptoms. If there is a priest willing to lend a hand, that would be even better…”

Duncan frowned.

He stepped into the warped room and slowly turned the door around to look at the back of the door panel.

He saw “Cristo Barbelli”.

There was a mass of something, clinging to the door like a half-melted, broken wax figure. In the sagging, twisted shape he could vaguely make out an arm pressed flat against the door panel, a few strands of tissue connecting to the hand, and a large lump of “body” whose true form could not be seen at all.

This horrible, twisted thing had fused with the door. When Duncan’s gaze fell upon it, it was still swelling and shrinking slightly, squirming as it spoke in a hoarse, low voice from somewhere inside its structure:

“Ah, I cannot see you. Have you come in? The room may be a bit messy. There was a big tremor earlier, and I have not tidied up since… My sight seems to have some problems, but they are not too serious. The worst part

now is that I cannot move my body. I think I have forgotten how to control my hands and feet. By the way, did you bring a doctor?”

Chapter 304: Sludge at the Bottom of the Hold

That was the “captain” of the Obsidian, Cristo Barbelli – a tangled mass of matter that almost no longer made anyone think of a human body, a heap that had floated up from the Deep Sea… a replica.

He seemed completely unaware of his own condition, and his mind also seemed a little broken.

He did not know time was passing, and he could not sense the twisting of his own flesh. After losing all sight, most of his sense of touch, and all ability to move, he still seemed far too calm, as if he was trapped in some strange dullness.

That faintly squirming, swelling mass of living tissue kept making a low, hoarse sound. “Cristo Barbelli” greeted the people who came into the room, asking about the current state of the Obsidian and asking what had happened.

Nina saw this strange and terrifying scene. She let out a low cry, then quickly forced it down, covered her mouth with one hand, and instinctively backed away two steps.

For a seventeen-year-old girl like her, this scene was a bit too much.

“The Obsidian had an accident, but we still don’t know the cause,” Duncan said. Facing this so-called Captain Cristo’s questions, he answered while quickly thinking about how to deal with him. “We were just passing by.”

“Ah, that is terrible… I have been trapped here all this time. I have no idea what is happening on the ship,” the mass of tissue stuck to the door let out a regretful sigh. “Is everything else still all right? What about the crew members and passengers? Did you find them?”

“…No, but we did not find any bodies either. They might already have escaped,” Duncan said casually. “Only this room was locked. We heard you knocking.”

“I kept knocking on this door. It is the only thing I can touch in the dark,” Captain Cristo said. “Storm Goddess Gamona preserve us, I hope everyone else is safe…”

The northern city-states were the domain of the God of Death Bartok, but on the Boundless Sea, the Storm Goddess’s divine authority was beyond doubt. No matter their homeland or faith, all captains prayed to the Storm Goddess when they went to sea.

As they listened to his prayer, Vanna and Morris both frowned.

This thing, which was clearly a twisted product, could still say a deity’s name correctly, and could even pray in a clear, sane way?

Duncan had clearly noticed this too. He also thought of what he had learned earlier from Tyrian about the Abyssal Trench Project.

During the Abyssal Trench Project’s runaway state, the “No. 3 Submersibles” that kept surfacing from the Deep Sea had all produced replicants that crawled out of them with no reason and no ability to communicate.

Even the first replicant – even that “replica” that looked the closest to humans – had only let out a few vague, muddled whispers.

That had been an important piece of information from the very beginning. Based on it, Tyrian had judged that those extraordinary manifestations in

the Deep Sea near Frostholm during the runaway state could only copy replicas without reason or souls. Yet this twisted entity in front of them, although its thinking and understanding seemed a bit off, clearly had normal reason and memories, and could even speak smoothly with others.

Where was the problem?

Was it because the Obsidian was not, as they first guessed, the same kind of replica as the “No. 3 Submersible”? Was the source of the twisting on this ship something else altogether? Or had the Deep Sea’s extraordinary manifestations near Frostholm changed in the past half century, so that the replicas it now created had begun to develop minds of their own?

Or…

Duncan quietly looked at “Captain Cristo,” who was stuck to the door.

Or maybe the captain’s own mind really was inside this mass of tissue – his soul had somehow been shoved into this twisted replica.

The more Duncan thought about it, the more he felt this was the most likely explanation.

“Are you still there?” Maybe Duncan stayed silent for too long, because Cristo’s voice came again from inside the tissue. “Can you help me get out of here? Or is my condition actually very bad? Is it… severe nerve damage?”

Duncan let out a sigh.

He knew he had to tell the man the truth, even if it was cruel.

Cruel things on the Boundless Sea were beyond counting.

But just as he was about to speak, Vanna’s voice suddenly came from the side and cut him off: “Mr. Cristo, your condition is indeed not good. We

cannot move you for now. You may need to stay here a bit longer – after we finish searching the other areas, we will think of a way to help you."

Duncan gave Vanna a questioning look. She raised her hand and pointed at the wall on the far side of the room.

There was a huge hole in that wall. On the other side of the opening was a sloping passage that led to somewhere unknown, dark and eerie inside.

Duncan understood what Vanna meant at once.

This ship still had far too many unexplored areas. Before they figured out what had happened to the Obsidian, they could not be certain what this "Captain Cristo" really was or where he had come from.

It was best to calm this strange "replica" for now and finish searching the whole ship before deciding what to do with him.

Duncan gave a small nod.

A professional was a professional. That sharp sense for danger clearly came from dealing with too many heretics and malevolent spirits.

"All right… I understand," Cristo said. His voice carried some regret and unease. "I will wait here. But how long will you be gone?"

"Maybe a few hours, but we will come back as soon as we can," Vanna said. "Please don't worry, we will not abandon you. Your condition is not good, but nothing serious will happen in the short term. Stay still, stay calm, and wait a while."

"Then… fine. Come back soon."

The squirming, swelling mass of tissue quieted down.

He seemed very anxious about his condition, but after Vanna's reassurance, he became surprisingly cooperative and calm.

Was the “captain” always like this by nature? Or was this calmness also a sign of his twisted thoughts and understanding? Duncan had no way to know.

Now, everyone’s attention turned to the big hole in the wall at the far end of the room.

Of course a normal room would not have such a hole, and would not have a crooked ramp hidden in that hole. This opening was clearly another result of the Obsidian’s twisted inner structure.

It looked deep and long. Where did it lead?

Duncan walked across the upside-down, jumbled room to the hole, leaned forward, and peered inside. He saw only darkness stretching down into the hollow, and a slanting passage that seemed to be pieced together from corridors and several twisted staircases. The passage extended downward. From time to time a draft of air blew up, as if there were more passages or a larger space at the bottom.

He stepped in. The others followed close behind.

The pigeon AI, wreathed in spirit form flames, once again became the search party’s torch. In the light of the spirit form fire, the corridor, already deep and gloomy, looked even stranger.

“The twisting down here seems even worse than above…”

Morris lifted his head and glanced at the shadowy ceiling where the light and dark crossed, speaking in a thoughtful tone.

Above the passage, they could vaguely see all kinds of tangled structures: stair railings, doors from who knew where, machine parts, pipes and wires, and even tables and chairs.

If the upper decks still held some vague trace of a normal layout, then this ramp leading deeper into the Obsidian was like a heap of junk made by grinding everything up and sticking it back together. It was a crisscrossing nightmare that stretched down into the steel giant's inner organs.

"It seems the closer you get to the replicant's center, the worse the copying accuracy becomes," Vanna said, then added, "If this ship really is a replicant similar to the 'No. 3 Submersible'."

"When we get back, I will have to talk with Tyrian," Duncan said from the front. "He may be very interested in what happened to the Obsidian."

"But I think before that, he will first be scared half to death by you," Vanna could not help muttering. "I have spoken with him. He has some serious shadows in his heart."

Duncan slowed down and looked back at Vanna.

Vanna instantly felt a bit awkward. "Did I say something wrong?"

"No." Duncan laughed. "I was just thinking that you can finally talk to me like a normal person. This feels right."

Vanna opened her mouth, as if she wanted to say something more, but at that moment, the light from AI in front of them suddenly dimmed. Right after that, their field of view opened up.

The passage had reached its end.

Below them was indeed a wide-open space.

"A cargo hold?" Morris frowned as he looked at the broad, dim place ahead. He saw a flat, open area. Compared to the twisted ramp they had just come down, this place was almost impossibly "orderly," yet he could not tell what this space had originally been used for.

“Don’t tell me the deepest part of this ghost ship is just an empty cavity,” Nina muttered nervously as she looked around. “Did everything get piled onto the upper two decks?”

No one could answer her.

Alice looked around curiously and walked forward a few steps.

“Eh?”

Miss Doll suddenly stopped and let out a short cry. She stared in shock at the floor under her feet and began wiping her shoe on the ground beside her.

“I think I stepped on something!” She turned back and said to Duncan with an innocent look. “It’s sticky and kind of gross…”

“Sticky?” Duncan frowned and quickly walked to Alice’s side. He looked down at the spot she had just stepped on.

He saw a dark patch of matter that looked like sludge. In the middle of that black, sticky stuff, he could still faintly see Alice’s shoe print.

But the shoe print was vanishing fast.

The “sludge” was squirming!

It was alive!

Chapter 305: 6000°C and a Heartbeat

Alive.

Once they realized that what Alice had stepped on was not sludge at all, but some kind of living tissue, most of the people present felt their skin crawl.

Duncan simply thought the things writhing on the floor were… disgusting.

Right after that, he heard Nina's voice from not far away: "There's some here too!"

"And over here!" Shirley cried out next. "A huge patch, and it's still moving!"

All over this mysterious, empty space lay those black, sludge-like "substances" that could slowly squirm.

"They're all over the place…" Vanna had silently drawn the greatsword from her back. She frowned as she surveyed the vast "hold" and spoke in a very serious tone. "Goddess preserve us… what are these things?"

Morris forced himself to ignore his disgust. He squatted by a patch of slowly moving "sludge" and used his folding knife to lift the edge of the sticky "mud."

"I have never seen anything like this, nor read of anything like it in any book," the learned old scholar said, full of unease and confusion. "It looks

like something living, but it feels just like mud, and… I do not sense any trace of a mind in it."

"It is somewhat similar to something Tyrian described from one of the 'No. 3 Submersibles'," Duncan said casually. At the same time, he raised his head and looked toward the deeper part of the hold.

Nina had walked to the edge of the group. In the dim light cast by AI's ghostly flames, a patch of sludge that looked especially "lively" was slowly rising and falling in a hollow in the floor. Nina stood beside the hollow, bent down, and watched the disgusting substance with curiosity.

She felt a little nervous, but her curiosity was even stronger than her nerves.

In the next second, the sludge suddenly stirred!

It was as if it was answering Nina's gaze, or like some blind, stupid creature that had finally been disturbed by this group of uninvited guests. The flow of the mud sped up all at once. A great amount of gas surged out from inside it, and bubbles rolled across its surface. Nina jumped in fright. Before she could react, the sludge suddenly… stood up!

Like a lowly soft-bodied creature that suddenly grew bones, the black, sticky mass straightened up out of the hollow. Its surface hardened, set, and changed color at high speed. In the blink of an eye, it took on a shape almost like a human. In the next instant, its top split and formed something like a head, and even grew a face.

It was a face that looked seventy or eighty percent like Nina's!

"Wah!" Nina cried out in fear. Even though she was brave, cheerful, and strong, she was still only a teenage girl. Faced with such a terrifying and bizarre sight, she was badly shaken. Her mind went blank on the spot. Without even thinking, she raised her hand on instinct to slap that awful thing away from her.

That slap had a temperature of 6000°C.

Shirley was the closest. She only heard Nina's startled cry, then a deafening boom. A blinding flash of searing light filled her and Dog's vision. With that flash came a shockwave of heat, like standing at the rim of an erupting volcano.

Nina had only slapped once, and it had been a very short slap.

But the fireball from that slap almost melted and vaporized a whole spherical space with a twelve-meter radius in front of her.

Duncan turned his head just in time to see the blazing ball of fire in front of Nina vanish quickly in midair. In front of her, glowing streams of molten metal were flowing where the metal had melted. The girl still seemed dazed. She was standing there, rooted to the edge of that terrifying molten pit.

"What happened?" Duncan hurried to Nina's side and put a hand on her shoulder. The leftover heat still rolled and shimmered around him.

"Just… just now that sludge suddenly stood up, and it turned into me, and I… I got scared…" Nina finally came back to herself. She hunched her shoulders, still pale with shock, and pointed toward where the strange thing had been. "So I hit it…"

"And then?"

"And then it was gone," Nina said with a miserable face, still a little frightened. "I didn't hold back. This whole area turned into molten iron."

Duncan looked blankly at the molten pit in the floor and the streams of metal running down the nearby wall. Then he looked at the still-nervous "fragment of the Sun."

Whatever that thing was that had jumped out to scare Nina, it was clearly the one that got hurt the worst. A 6000°C slap like that… even an eldritch god from Subspace would be left with lifelong shadows from it…

Still, he reached out and ruffled Nina's hair, comforting the young lady who had just been badly frightened: "Don't be scared. It's fine. You already slapped it out of existence…"

As he spoke, he turned and looked at the others, who were all shaken.

Shirley was hugging Dog and shaking like a leaf. Morris was quietly thumping his own chest. Alice had just picked up her head. Only Vanna stayed the calmest. She looked at Duncan and shrugged.

"I will never again walk up behind Nina and start talking to her suddenly," said the Inquisitor who had once slaughtered her way through an entire city-state, in a very solemn tone.

"It was just a small accident," Duncan said helplessly as he rubbed Nina's hair. Then his gaze went back to the patches of sludge that Nina's "Sun punch" had not reached. A second later, his expression changed slightly. "Wait, something is wrong with these things."

At Duncan's warning, everyone finally noticed the changes in the sludge all over the hold.

All the sludge had stopped moving.

These things that had been twisting and shifting like soft-bodied creatures only moments ago had all frozen. They had become dry clumps, like mud that had lost its water. At the edges of every clump, tiny branch-like protrusions stretched outward, as if something had tried to escape from inside the mud and left marks pointing in the direction it had fled.

Vanna's eyes swept around the hold at once. In only a few seconds, she noticed that the marks reaching out from the edges of the sludge all seemed

to point the same way.

Toward the deepest part of the dark hold.

“There is something in that direction.” Vanna spoke at once and gripped her greatsword tighter.

At the same time, Duncan also turned his gaze toward the deepest darkness.

A thin line of ghostly green flame stretched quietly out from under his feet. When it touched the dry clumps of “sludge” on the floor, it flared up bright at once, turning into one bonfire after another. The “campfires” spread across the hold in moments, lighting many places that had been in darkness.

Duncan watched the spreading fires and confirmed his first guess in his heart – these sludge-like things were condensed from extraordinary power.

As the spirit form flames spread, this wide hold that had been too large for AI’s firelight to brighten fully finally revealed more of its secrets.

They saw distant bulkheads scarred and pitted as if burned by acid or gnawed by some corrupt creature. They saw ropes, pipes, and suspicious dark red bundles of fibers hanging from above. They saw even more sludge clumps that had already lost all life. And at the very deepest point of the hold, they saw—

A huge, blurred mass crouched there in an unsettling posture. Its edges still seemed to be slowly writhing.

Duncan paused for a moment, then strode toward that giant, twisted heap.

He did not let his spirit form flames corrupt and burn the mass. He knew it was also “extraordinary firewood” that he could burn, but before he understood what it was, he did not want to destroy any clues.

The others hesitated for a moment, but when they saw Duncan already walking forward with big strides, they quickly followed behind him.

“Thump—”

Just as Duncan had gone halfway, a sudden sound made everyone stop without thinking.

Morris looked up toward the source of the sound and realized that the dull thump, like a heartbeat, was coming from deep inside that several-meter-high dark heap.

Duncan stopped as well. He stared at the strange mass and felt the flow of its aura.

It did not give him any sense of danger.

So he took a few more steps forward.

“Thump… thump…”

The heartbeat-like sound became clearer and stronger than before. The edges of the mass writhed more obviously, and even its whole surface began to rise and fall.

Duncan frowned. At that moment, he suddenly heard Shirley’s voice behind him:

“Dog, Dog, what’s wrong with you?!”

Chapter 306: Remains in the Depths

Dog staggered forward on unsteady legs for two steps, then finally stopped. Thick, pitch-black smoke and dust rose from the gaps in its bones. Every bone plate on its body trembled as if in spasm, and in its blood-red eye sockets, the light flickered on and off.

Such an obvious reaction from this Anomaly naturally startled Shirley. She stopped at once, grabbed Dog's huge skull, and shook it while calling his name in a panic. She called seven or eight times before Dog finally came back to his senses. Dog slowly raised his head and let out a hoarse, low sound from its throat: "Why did I suddenly… feel like I can't move my legs…"

"Are you alright?" Duncan also walked over at this time. He frowned as he looked at the Abyssal Hound, whose state was clearly wrong. There was some concern in his voice as he asked: "Does anything hurt?"

"I… don't feel sick," Dog's skull swayed as if it could fall asleep at any moment. "I just feel like I don't have any strength, and… I really don't want to go near that pile of stuff."

"You really don't want to get close?" Duncan turned his head and looked at that strange thing at the end of the room, which still slowly writhed in the firelight like a hill of sludge.

Was that weird "sludge" affecting Dog? Some kind of instinctive suppressive force?

Dog’s strange reaction drew everyone’s attention and also pushed Duncan into thought. The first thing he thought of was whether Dog’s strange “senses”, which far surpassed those of humans, had once again noticed something invisible.

But judging from Dog’s reaction, Dog did not seem to have “seen” any kind of Anomaly.

“The Abyssal Hound counts as a rather powerful bloodline among Abyssal demons. They rarely end up like this just because they face the pressure of a strong individual,” Vanna squatted down and, without any hesitation, patted Dog’s bone plates. Then she turned and glanced toward the end of the room. “Besides, that thing hasn’t released any aura of pressure at all…”

“You can take out ‘rather’,” Shirley muttered to the side. “Dog is already really strong…”

“I’m not strong, not strong at all,” Dog quickly shook his head. “Isn’t this place a bit too creepy? Maybe we should come back next time?”

“There won’t be a next time. This ghost ship may not stay here obediently, waiting for us to explore it over and over,” Duncan shook his head. “But you really aren’t in any condition to keep going.”

Dog was clearly under the influence of some unknown power. If he kept forcing Dog toward that thing, it could lead to unpredictable results. The best choice now was to send Dog and Shirley back to the Vanished for the time being.

Duncan waved to the side. AI immediately flew over, circling in the air while squawking: “Who is calling the ship… It’s a trap! Abandon ship!”

“You take Shirley and Dog back to the Vanished first,” Duncan ignored the noisy bird. He pointed at Dog, who was sprawled on the ground, and at

Shirley, who looked very worried. Then, after thinking for a moment, he pointed at Nina as well. “Take Nina back too.”

“Ah?” Nina did not react at first. “Why do I have to go back? I feel fine right now!”

“That thing just now tried to copy you. It was interrupted by you, but we don’t know how that mass at the end will react when you get close,” Duncan explained simply. “In a situation like this, it doesn’t hurt to be extra careful.”

Nina listened carefully, then nodded obediently at once: “Ah, alright, I’ll go back then.”

Duncan had prepared a lot of words to persuade her. After all, Nina was a curious young lady and had always looked forward to this kind of adventure. He didn’t expect her to agree so quickly, which left him a bit surprised, but soon he just smiled and shook his head.

She was still so sensible.

The undead bird’s flames roared through the cabin, taking Shirley, Dog, and Nina out of the Obsidian.

But the space did not fall into darkness because AI left. The bonfires Duncan had lit with that dry, sluggish sludge as fuel still burned, lighting up this gloomy, eerie place.

That strange mass at the end of the cabin still lay there, quietly writhing as if half-asleep, as if lurking in a dream.

But as soon as Duncan turned his gaze back on it, a clear “thump” sounded from inside that mass.

“The children are gone,” Duncan let out a gentle breath and walked toward the dark mass. “Now it’s time for the adults to solve this problem.”

His steps did not hesitate at all. As he moved closer, the mass that had seemed to be in a dormant state reacted at once. The writhing at its edges grew more obvious, the swelling and shrinking of its surface became more frequent, and the beating sounds from within grew faster and louder.

When he was ten meters away, it had already turned into a clear rhythm of a heartbeat –

Thump, thump, thump – the clear, powerful heartbeat echoed again and again, ringing through the wide, dim cabin.

But aside from the constant heartbeat and the ever-stronger writhing on its surface, the thing did not show any other reaction.

Even when Duncan stood right in front of it, it only kept up this “full of life” state.

“Goddess… what on earth is this blasphemous thing…”

Vanna spoke with her brow tightly furrowed, unable to hide the disgust in her voice.

Now that she was close enough, she could finally see the true shape of this mass more clearly. It did not have any outline that a living creature should have. Its surface flowed like mud, yet from time to time questionable bumps rose beneath that mud, like half-melted organs or suddenly swelling blood vessels and bundles of nerves. At the same time, as it kept making heartbeat sounds, it showed some traits that looked like responses to outside stimuli – traits that, in the end, still just turned back into blind, pointless squirming.

From the day she became an Inquisitor, Vanna had seen more heretical evil than she could count. Yet the level of blasphemy and corruption in this thing still shocked her deeply.

Even Alice at the side looked a little dazed. The doll stared at the pile of flesh for a long time before finally saying: “It doesn’t look like something you can cook…”

Vanna’s eyes widened at once as she stared at Alice – she was shocked yet again.

Morris, on the other hand, showed the carefulness and curiosity a Scholar should have. He seemed to ignore the discomfort and resistance in his heart. He stepped closer to the mass and studied it for quite a while. Then, as it swelled and writhed, he suddenly noticed something: “There seems to be something wrapped inside!”

“Inside?” Duncan was slightly startled. Right away he noticed what Morris had seen: near the edge of the sludge, there was a small strip of something that looked like a torn piece of clothing.

Was this constantly writhing sludge just a covering layer?

Realizing this, Duncan immediately reached out his hand and pointed at the writhing mass.

The many bonfires burning around the cabin instantly stretched out thin lines of flame. Streams of spirit form fire almost gathered onto that “living mud” in the blink of an eye.

The spirit form flames blazed up at once.

The fire was fierce, yet under precise control. Duncan ordered the flames to only burn away the black sludge and not harm whatever lay inside. Under his conscious pushing and control, it took only a few seconds for that disgusting writhing mass to be burned away completely.

The thing that had been buried deep under the sludge finally appeared before everyone’s eyes.

“This is…”

Morris stared at the scene in front of him in shock.

A human, a middle-aged man, leaned against a pile of wreckage and lay among the embers left behind by the spirit form flames. His eyes were wide with rage, as if in his final moments he had been fighting some fierce enemy with his life. Yet one of his hands covered his mouth in a death grip, as if he had been holding back some immense terror. His body was in a horrifying state –

More than half of his body had been dissolved by something, broken down into a structure that made one’s skin crawl.

Only one heart was left, exposed outside his open chest cavity, beating slowly yet strongly.

Thump… thump… thump…

The heartbeat, filled with some powerful will, echoed through the whole cabin.

So the heartbeat Duncan had heard on the way over had been coming from this heart.

But this human was clearly long dead. His heartbeat did not mean any life at all.

“A human?” Vanna instantly furrowed her brow again, watching the middle-aged man who had died in the deepest part of the Obsidian with great caution. “Is this also a replica created by the Obsidian?”

“His twisted, mutated body structure matches the traits of a replica, but something about it still seems off…” Morris muttered under his breath. He carefully prodded the remaining parts of the corpse’s limbs with his Gatekeeper’s cane. Studying the scattered scraps of clothing, he tried to

figure out what they had looked like when intact. “These clothes… they look like a uniform.”

“It is a uniform,” Duncan suddenly said. He seemed to have noticed something. As he spoke, he bent down, ignoring the terrifying remains, and felt around near the still-beating heart. From a strip of torn cloth, he took off a small object.

It was a small metal badge.

On it were written a title and a name.

“He was the captain of the Obsidian, Cristo Barbelli,” Duncan looked at the badge and said calmly.

—

Chapter 307: The Chunk of Flesh

On the small metal badge, Cristo Barbelli's name and the title of captain of the Obsidian were stamped into the surface.

The badge made the atmosphere in the cabin turn quiet and eerie all at once. In the wide, silent space, only the thump-thump of the heart could be heard.

"His name was Cristo?" After a long time, Alice finally broke the silence. She scratched her hair, looking puzzled. "But the 'person' we saw behind that blue door also said his name was Cristo, right?"

"If this ship came from Frostholm and the Deep Sea, then everything on board could be twisted replicas. Any pile of Twisted Entities here could be Cristo, or anyone else who had been on the Obsidian at the time," Duncan said lightly, his gaze falling on the middle-aged man on the floor, who lay with his eyes wide and his hand over his mouth. "The key is this… this corpse is obviously very special."

"You suspect he is the original?" Vanna caught on quickly. She stared at Duncan in shock. "But… the whole ship is obviously a twisted copy. How could the original be here?"

"…Everything we know about Frostholm and the Deep Sea comes from Tyrian's limited memories. And even what Tyrian knew was only some early-stage information from the Abyssal Trench Project. The project never truly revealed the secrets below one thousand meters under the sea," Duncan shook his head. "We know very little about the seabed around Frostholm. Our conclusions about how these replicas work could easily be

wrong. Maybe the originals are hidden inside the replica shells. Maybe every single replica is a piece cut from the original. It's even possible that beneath the Deep Sea, there is no real difference between replica and original at all."

As Vanna listened, she couldn't help glancing at Alice beside her.

But Alice didn't think about any of that. She only stared curiously at "Cristo Barbelli" on the floor. After pondering for a while, she suddenly asked: "Why is he covering his mouth?"

"People often act like that when they're afraid," Morris said casually. "Nothing strange about it."

But before he finished speaking, Duncan's voice suddenly cut in: "No, it is strange… He wasn't doing it because of fear."

Morris looked at Duncan in surprise. He saw Duncan crouch down beside the twisted, frightening corpse, even leaning close to its face as if he wanted to study something.

Thump, thump, thump.

Cristo Barbelli's heart kept beating. As Duncan leaned closer, it seemed to beat even faster and stronger than before.

Duncan noticed the change in the heart, but most of his attention stayed on the captain's face. After studying it carefully, he suddenly found something.

"There's something in his mouth."

"There's something in his mouth?" Morris was startled. Then he saw Duncan reach out, trying to pry the corpse's hand away from its mouth.

The resistance in that hand surprised Duncan.

The corpse was still covering its own mouth with all its strength, as if even after so many years of death, it was still consciously resisting something.

Duncan did not use much force at first, and he actually failed to pull the hand away. He knew that if he really tried, he could easily crush the will of the dead. But before he used more force, a thought came to him and he suddenly stopped.

“Mr. Barbelli, if you were guarding some secret, you can let go now,” Duncan looked into those wide, furious eyes and spoke in a calm voice. “You can leave what comes next to me.”

The hand loosened.

Underneath was a mouth with clenched teeth – but a second later, those jaws relaxed too.

Vanna and Morris exchanged shocked looks. Then they saw Duncan reach out again and feel around inside Cristo’s slightly open mouth.

A soft and slightly disgusting sensation met his hand. Duncan frowned, pushed down the discomfort in his heart, and pulled out the lump he had found in the dead man’s mouth.

It was a chunk only as big as a thumb, dull in color, with faint blue threads running through it. It was very soft to the touch. When Duncan squeezed it, it felt… like some kind of meat.

Meat that had been bitten off from some larger being.

“What is that?” Alice was the first to lean over in curiosity. She clung to Duncan’s arm and stared at the unmoving, blackish-blue chunk of flesh in his hand. Then her face twisted in disgust. “Ugh… I don’t like it…”

Duncan glanced at Alice in surprise. This doll, who was cheerful all day long, rarely showed such quick and clear disgust toward anything.

Right after Alice spoke, Vanna also frowned: “I sense a very disturbing aura from it. It reminds me of certain corruptions that float up from the deep layers of the world into the Mortal Realm.”

“My instincts tell me it’s best not to stare at it too long,” Morris added quickly. “This is probably a warning from the God of Wisdom. Don’t you feel anything when you hold it?”

“Feel? No,” Duncan squeezed the flesh in his hand. “The texture is a bit gross, but I don’t feel the kind of extreme reaction you’re describing.”

“Oh, that’s normal. Your rank is different from ours,” Morris said, not surprised at all. Then he went on: “But one thing is certain. What you’re holding definitely doesn’t belong in the Mortal Realm. It should be the most important clue on this ghost ship…”

He stopped halfway through his sentence.

Because everyone heard it: the beating of that heart in the air was fading fast.

Duncan lowered his head and looked into Cristo’s chest, which had been opened by corrosion and distortion. The heart that had been beating so strongly just moments before was now turning gray-white. In a few seconds, its thumping weakened almost to nothing. Then, under his gaze, the heart suddenly burst into flame and turned to ash in the blink of an eye.

At the same time, a low, hoarse voice that sounded strangely familiar rang in everyone’s ears. The voice had no clear source. It sounded almost like the whole ship was sighing: “Ah, so that’s how it was…”

Vanna reacted first: “It’s the voice from behind the blue door!”

Duncan looked down at the remains on the floor and saw the “captain Cristo” melting like wax. The corpse, which should have been washed away

by the sea six years ago, seemed to be making up for those lost years of decay all at once, turning into jagged bone fragments almost in an instant.

He made his decision at once and turned back the way they had come: “We’re going back the way we came.”

Their speed on the way back was much faster than when they had been exploring.

The group moved quickly through the wide, dead, eerie cabin, back through the twisted sloping passage. It didn’t take long for them to return to the “captain’s room” with the blue door.

The door was half open. Behind it, the living tissue that called itself “Cristo Barbelli” still clung quietly to the wooden boards.

Vanna stepped forward. Almost at once, the mass of tissue seemed to sense the movement around it. Its surface began to writhe as it spoke in a hoarse, low voice: “Ah, you are back.”

“…Captain Cristo,” Vanna steadied herself and tried to keep her voice calm. “We have a few things…”

But before she could finish, “Cristo” cut her off: “I already know, lady – I remembered.”

Even though she had a faint guess in her heart, Vanna still couldn’t help asking: “You… remembered?”

“If you mean my own death, then yes, I remembered, though only part of it,” Cristo said in a low voice. “I died, didn’t I? Of course I died… The Obsidian has sunk. We met a storm and icebergs. We went down, kept sinking into endless darkness. There was no way I survived.”

Duncan stayed quiet for a few seconds, then suddenly stepped forward: “Do you know what happened in the depths of this ship?”

“The depths?” Cristo’s voice sounded puzzled.

“Do you remember the details of your death?” Duncan asked again. “Did you fight something? After you sank into the Deep Sea, did anything else happen on the ship?”

Cristo fell silent, as if deep in thought. After a moment, the living tissue spoke again with a hint of regret: “Sorry, I don’t remember those details. I only remember… the ship was sinking, sinking all the time. It was a very, very long process. Everyone died. I should have died too, but I kept drifting in the dark. It was cold around me and very dim. It felt like I was looking for something in the dark. I don’t know how long that confusion lasted – and when I had memories again, I was already knocking on this door.”

Duncan exchanged a look with the others.

“Captain Cristo” had no reason to lie.

This captain had only realized that he was already dead. He did not remember what had happened in the deepest parts of the Obsidian. He didn’t know that “another him” had died in the eerie space at the bottom of the ship, and he knew nothing about the chunk of mysterious flesh.

The trail seemed to have broken.

But Duncan lowered his head and looked at his palm – the dark chunk of flesh still lay quietly there.

He had already gained something very important.

Chapter 308: Dog’s Fierce Reaction

Inside the room with the blue door, Duncan and the others stayed silent. The twisted mass of living tissue stuck to the door panel also stayed silent for a long time.

After an unknown stretch of time, Duncan finally broke the silence: “Is there anything else you need us to do for you?”

“I do not think I have any regrets,” Cristo’s voice came from the door. “I cannot think of anything to ask for either. Good Samaritan, what could you do for a restless soul who has been dead for so many years?”

“What about your family?” Vanna could not help asking.

“Family…” Cristo clearly hesitated, as if some memories had only just appeared inside this twisted ‘body’. “Oh, right, my family… my wife and daughter. They live in Frostholm, at the end of Hearth Street…”

Cristo mumbled softly, his voice growing lower and lower, as if he was about to fall asleep. But all of a sudden he woke up again, and his voice became a little clearer: “Ah… if you ever get the chance, go and see them for me. Carry a message back. Even though they should already know what happened to the Obsidian.”

“Is there anything special you want us to tell them?” Vanna asked.

This time, Cristo thought for a long time. Just when Vanna thought he was going to fall asleep again, the squirming mass of flesh suddenly spoke: “I cannot think of anything. I cannot even remember what they look like

anymore… Just tell them good morning for me. Tell them I left with no real regrets and not much pain. That is all."

"We will pass it on, if they are still at that address," Duncan said with a light nod. At the same time, his gaze fell on Cristo's body – that faintly writhing, swelling mass of flesh.

It was not an illusion. The living tissue was slowly losing its vitality. Cristo's mind seemed to be leaving this body bit by bit, and a thin layer of dull gray was spreading along the edges of the mass.

All these changes were probably related to that heart deep inside the Obsidian that had stopped beating.

It was time to leave.

"We should go," Duncan said calmly.

"It is about that time…" Cristo's voice became lower and more blurred, but it was still clear enough to hear. "Then I wish you a smooth voyage ahead. Just leave me here. A captain should stay with his ship."

"…In fact, we are going to sink this ship before we leave," Duncan hesitated for two or three seconds, then still chose to tell him what would happen next. "Captain Cristo, you can probably guess. The Obsidian has already been corrupted. We cannot let this ship keep drifting on the Boundless Sea. It is a threat to ordinary sailors."

Cristo stayed silent for a moment, then spoke softly: "Thank you, Good Samaritan."

Duncan watched this captain for a few seconds and nodded quietly, ready to turn and leave.

But just as he was about to step past the door, Cristo's voice suddenly sounded in his ear again: "Among you… is there a believer of Death God

Bartok?”

“…I am sorry, no,” Vanna shook her head. “Why do you ask?”

“Ah, I was only hoping that a believer of Death God Bartok could help me with a soul-sending prayer,” Cristo said. “After everything that has happened, my soul is no longer clean. I doubt I can pass through Bartok’s gate of life and death. If there was a soul-sending prayer, maybe my soul could disperse a bit faster… But if not, then forget it. Life rarely goes the way we want, does it?”

Vanna and Morris instinctively glanced at each other. After a brief pause, Morris spoke: “We are clerics of the Storm Goddess and the God of Wisdom. We will pray for you after we leave – though for a believer of Death God Bartok, it may not have much effect.”

“I do not know much about Death God Bartok,” Duncan said as he stepped forward and took the hand stuck to the door panel. “But if this is a dying believer’s greatest wish… then I hope you get what you wish for.”

“…Thank you, Good Samaritan.”

No more sound came from the squirming mass of flesh. Its movements grew slower and slower. The gray of death had spread across it. He was not completely dead yet, but his last bit of life was no longer enough to support a conversation.

Duncan nodded silently to the captain of the Obsidian, then stepped through the door.

They left the Obsidian’s captain’s cabin, passed through the twisted, upside-down corridor, went through the three nested doors, and returned to the deck of the ghost ship.

The sun was already leaning toward the west.

With a heavy beat of wings, the undead bird wrapped in blazing flame flew over from the direction of the Vanished and circled above Duncan and the others.

Pale green fire rose from the Obsidian, then turned into a falling star and flew back to the nearby Vanished.

A moment later, the Vanished slowly adjusted her position. The gunport shutters on one side of the hull all lifted, and one dark cannon muzzle after another slid out through the firing slits.

The cannons roared. Fiery meteors fell like rain. In the ever-tilting sunset, now faintly the color of blood, the Obsidian was wrapped in raging green ghost-flame almost in the blink of an eye. In a series of spectacular bursts of fire and explosions, she took on water, broke apart, and sank.

The ghost ship that had been completely corrupted by extraordinary power sank into the Deep Sea in a very short time, leaving only a few swirling whirlpools on the surface.

At the edge of the Vanished's deck, Duncan faced the sunset and fixed his gaze on the place where the Obsidian was going down, watching the ghost ship until her very last moment.

Only after she had fully vanished beneath the waves did he pull back his gaze and look at Vanna and Morris, who were standing behind him.

"Sailing long-distance on the Boundless Sea is one of the most dangerous jobs in this world, and deep-sea captains are in the most dangerous position of all," Morris said with a hint of emotion. "More than half of all deep-sea captains meet bad ends. Even those who manage to retire alive and settle on land rarely blend into the life of ordinary people. Most of them suffer under the curse and mental anomalies. Hallucinations of sound and sight and even

broken memories haunt them all their lives. My daughter Heidi… deals with things like that all the time."

Duncan did not respond to the old scholar's sigh.

After all, from the view of ordinary people, this ship, the Vanished, and he himself, 'Captain Duncan'… were also examples of those who did not meet a good end.

His 'bad end', though, was a bit more intense than most.

"How are Shirley and Dog?" Duncan suddenly asked.

"I just went to see them," Alice raised her hand at once. "Dog said he is fine now. He is studying Nina's primary school textbooks. Shirley said Dog needs someone to look after him, so she is napping beside Dog."

"…A Abyssal Hound chasing knowledge and his illiterate master," Duncan's mouth twitched as he started toward the cabins. "I will go check on them."

He went straight to the cabin that Shirley and Dog shared and knocked on the door, only to find it was only resting against the frame. He pushed it open and saw a certain dog sitting on his hind legs at the desk, holding a little primary school vocabulary book between his front paws and reading it with great interest.

And on the bed behind the dog, Shirley the illiterate was sleeping like a log.

Duncan's mouth twitched again. He had already heard Alice describe this, but actually seeing such a strange scene still felt uncanny. Dog heard the sound at the door, looked up, and said: "Oh, Captain, you… ah, crap!!!"

He did not even finish his greeting before the Abyssal Hound suddenly let out a cracked, metallic scream. Then the whole dog shot up from the chair with a bang, almost jumping to the ceiling.

There was another loud crash as the black chain linking Dog and Shirley snapped tight. Shirley, who had been sleeping soundly on the bed, was dragged into the air and slammed hard into the nearby wall with a heavy thud.

“Dog, are you crazy?!” Shirley, knocked dizzy, bounced to her feet as soon as she hit the floor and lunged at Dog. “What are you doing, suddenly…”

She finally noticed Duncan standing at the door, and also saw Dog’s terrified look.

“Dog, are you okay?”

Shirley and Duncan spoke almost at the same time.

“I am fine, I am fine… no, no, I am not fine…” Dog still had not fully recovered. He was trembling all over, his eyes darting around. He seemed to want to look in Duncan’s direction, but his instincts made him avoid it. After holding it in for a long time, he finally squeezed out: “Captain, are you carrying something… in your left pocket…”

“Something?” Duncan froze, then reacted. He reached into his left pocket and took out a small metal case that he had once used to hold tobacco.

He opened the metal case. Inside lay a thumb-sized, dark, strange piece of “flesh”.

“I-I-I… what the…!” Dog became even more nervous the instant he saw that thing. He shot into the corner of the room in one bound. “W-w-where did that… come from?!”

“From the deepest part of the Obsidian,” Duncan said with a frown. “Why are you reacting like this? From this thing you…”

“The Abyssal Lord! The Abyssal Lord’s presence!” Dog was shaking so hard he might as well have been set to vibrate. “This is the Abyssal Lord’s

flesh and blood!”

Chapter 309: Dog’s rotten Luck

This time Duncan really stayed stunned for several seconds before he understood what Dog meant – not because he did not understand the words, but because he needed a moment to digest this shocking fact.

“Are you sure?” He picked up the little gray-black chunk of flesh with faint blue in it from the metal case and squeezed it between his fingers. “This thing is a part of the Abyssal Lord?”

“You… you are still squeezing it?!” Dog’s voice went sharp as he watched Duncan’s far-too-relaxed actions. “Do you not feel the vast pressure and power coming off it at all?”

“No,” Duncan shook his head, then added, “And it is not just me. Vanna and Morris did not react much either. They only felt that it was dangerous or unsettling, but nothing like what you are doing.”

As Duncan spoke, Dog had already crouched low to the floor without noticing. He lay beside the desk in a pose of total alertness. The blood-red glow in his eyes flickered brighter and dimmer. After a long time, he muttered: “It does seem to have lost its vitality… or maybe you are suppressing its vitality, but I cannot tell. I am a Abyssal demon. I have an inseparable link with the Abyssal Lord. In my eyes… there is only endless shadow and pressure.”

“It is probably related to your nature,” Duncan said as he snapped the tobacco case shut and casually put it back into his pocket. He noticed Dog

relax a lot as he did. “I will put it away first. You might feel a bit better that way.”

“Th-thank you, Captain,” Dog finally stopped shaking quite so hard. He wobbled to his feet but still looked badly shaken, his eyes fixed on Duncan’s pocket. “You just said… that flesh was brought out from the deepest part of the Obsidian?”

“Yes. And it came from the mouth of a mortal,” Duncan said with a soft sigh. He told them what had happened after Dog and Shirley were sent back to the Vanished. “We found this sample of flesh in Cristo Barbelli’s mouth.”

After hearing the full story, Dog’s shock was written all over his face.

He lifted his head and met Shirley’s eyes. For half a minute, neither of them spoke. After who knew how long, Shirley finally smacked her lips and broke the silence: “So you are saying… that captain named Cristo… bit off a piece of flesh from a deity before he died… By the way, does the Abyssal Lord count as a deity?”

“For mortals, there is no difference. ‘Like a deity’ is a very broad concept,” Dog said slowly, his tone serious, shaking his head. “I… still cannot believe it. I cannot imagine how he did it. Mortals in front of the Abyssal Lord do not even have the strength to move a finger, let alone fight back or resist… And besides, how did he even see the Abyssal Lord?”

“Did the Obsidian once enter the Abyssal Deep’s Deep Sea?” Duncan frowned at once. “After she sank off Frostholm’s coast, she did not simply keep sinking in the Mortal Realm’s Deep Sea, but was teleported away? Or… is the Deep Sea beneath Frostholm actually connected to the realm of the Abyssal demons?”

“I do not think that is possible,” Dog said at once, shaking his head hard. “I have never heard of any place in the Abyssal Deep’s Deep Sea being

directly linked to the Mortal Realm's dimension. If there really was a leak between those two places, in six years the city-state of Frostholm would already have been torn apart by the demons pouring out. The Obsidian sank six years ago."

Duncan thought for a moment.

But he had far too little information now. No matter how much he tried to reason it out, it was hard to find a convincing explanation.

Only one thing was certain: the piece of "flesh" brought out from the Obsidian was quite dangerous. It was best not to take it out casually.

Of course, he had thought about burning it at once or loading it into the Vanished's main gun and firing it into the distance. From the feedback he felt when he touched the flesh, Duncan believed this thing could also be used as "extraordinary firewood" and burned up by spirit flame. But after a short weighing of the options, he still decided to keep it for now.

In case it turned out to be useful one day.

As he thought, Duncan's attention returned to Dog.

The Abyssal Hound had calmed down a bit. He was now purposely not thinking about the "Lord's flesh". He already looked much better.

"Are the other Abyssal demons like you?" Duncan asked.

"Huh?" Dog did not react at first. "You mean…"

"Abyssal demons all come from the 'Lord'. You told me before that powerful Abyssal demons even live right beside the Lord," Duncan said, his gaze resting on the blood-red eyes in Dog's sockets. "But you react like this when you get close to the Abyssal Lord's presence. Then how do you all usually live beside the Lord? Do you just shake like that every day?"

Dog froze. He clearly had not expected the captain's imagination to jump that far, or in such detail. But after a brief silence, he still shook his head and admitted: "Normal Abyssal demons… would not react like I do."

"Oh?"

"Sanity is the precondition of madness," Dog sighed. "Only those with wisdom understand fear. Only those with humanity can tell human from beast. I turned away from the 'path' of normal Abyssal demons, so I lost the right to stay near the Abyssal Lord."

Shirley blinked, then suddenly realized something: "Dog, did you just say something really deep and meaningful?!"

"Sanity is the precondition of madness…" Duncan ignored Shirley's loud exclamation and only repeated the words under his breath, thoughtful. "So now you cannot return to your 'homeland', but you also cannot cut off your link to the Abyssal Lord. You can no longer get close to the Lord's presence, yet you are extremely sensitive to that presence?"

Dog hugged his head and sighed: "…That is about right."

"Then you really are unlucky."

Dog sounded close to tears: "Under normal circumstances, no one would suddenly wave a piece of the Lord's flesh in front of me and squeeze it, okay… This is supposed to be the safe, stable Mortal Realm dimension!"

"That really was my mistake," Duncan said, apologizing with genuine sincerity. "I did not think of it before."

"No, no, no, please do not apologize to me!" Dog was startled and scrambled under the desk. "If you just toss out an apology, Subspace might latch onto me again…"

“…All right,” Duncan said, stunned for a moment before a strange smile came to his face. He shook his head and turned to leave. “Then I will not bother you. Keep reading.”

Shirley hurried to her feet to see him out, but Duncan suddenly stopped again and turned back to look at her.

“You should learn from Dog. He can already read primary school stories. You still spell your own name wrong three times out of five. Do you not feel embarrassed?”

Shirley answered without shame: “Dog is a demon who chases knowledge. Of course he learns fast! How can I compare to him?”

“First, that is not how you use the phrase ‘chases knowledge’. Second, even if Dog is a demon who chases knowledge, you do not have to walk in circles around knowledge all day,” Duncan said, sounding a bit helpless. “In a few days I have to arrange an exam for you two. I want to see how much you have actually learned.”

After leaving those words, he turned and walked out of the room, closing the door behind him.

After he waited at the door for a few seconds, Shirley’s wail of despair and string of curses rang out, just as he had expected.

A cheerful smile appeared on Duncan’s face.

He set off toward the captain’s cabin.

…

Night grew deeper.

In the Sea Mist Fleet’s home port – sealed and hidden by fog, drifting ice, and strange, chaotic currents – Tyrian walked slowly along a small road by the edge of the docks.

The cold night wind blew in from the sea. The sound of waves breaking on the shore rose and fell. The cold, dim glow of the World's Wound soaked the whole island, and from somewhere far off in the air came the faint roar of a noisy gathering in the harbor square.

The sailors were holding a party. They used wine, tobacco, and loud instruments to drive away the hollowness left in the world by the dead, and they used a whole night of noise to burn off their cold, endless energy. But for Tyrian, such gatherings were still too noisy.

They were not good for calm thinking.

Another set of footsteps followed behind him.

It was his loyal first mate, Aiden. Right now, he still smelled like a strip of bacon, but now there were hints of cinnamon and clove mixed in.

The smell made Tyrian sigh to himself. People from Pland really had a lot of tricks when it came to tobacco.

"You can go join the party in the square," Tyrian said suddenly. "You do not have to walk with me in this quiet place."

"I am waiting for the second half of the night," Aiden said. "They invited twelve Bardica dancers from Cold Harbor – they have real stamina."

"…"

"Captain?"

"In weather this cold, they are coming to dance on an island full of Living dead pirates, and in the middle of the night, no less. Be honest. What kind of damned price did you people offer them?"

"Actually, not that much," Aiden said, rubbing his shiny bald head with a grin. "When the Sea Crow went out on business last week, she happened to

rescue the ship of ‘Scimitar Martin’. You know, Martin controls a quarter of the theaters and troupes in Cold Harbor…”

Tyrian: “…”

The commander of the Sea Mist Fleet stood in the night wind for a few seconds in silence, pinched the bridge of his nose, and then let his expression return to normal.

“Let us talk about the situation on Dagger Island instead.”

“Yes, Captain.”

Chapter 310: Pirate Island Under the veil of night

Ever since the eighth “No. 3 Submersible” was salvaged in the waters near Frostholm and brought to the nearby Dagger Island, The authority of the city-state had turned that island into a military restricted zone. The two nearby stretches of The route were no longer open to civilian traffic.

This, of course, stirred up all kinds of guesses. It was not only the locals of Frostholm who were speculating. Shipowners who had been forced away from Dagger Island, and the pirates and explorers nearby, were guessing too. They wondered what had happened on that island and what secret Frostholm’s authority was hiding there.

Many of the rumors even sounded detailed and serious, ranging from “researching a new type of weapon” to “holding a dangerous ritual” and so on—yet none of them were reliable.

There were not many people left in the world who still knew about the Abyssal Trench Project.

“It is getting harder and harder for our people to gather information on Dagger Island,” Aiden said with a serious face. The two of them were walking along a path at the edge of the harbor district. He turned to Tyrian as he spoke. “They have changed the level of blockade on that island. They are watching every inch of the shoreline now. It is no longer possible to get close by diving.

“As for the informants and inside men we bought or controlled, they have all been transferred away from key posts recently. They have not been exposed, but now all supplies and personnel movements for Dagger Island are handled entirely within a special list under The authority. We cannot get our hands into it anymore.”

“So it has become a full military forbidden zone…” Tyrian stopped walking. “Did they find something on that ‘No. 3 Submersible’? Or did they already open the hatch?”

“Hard to say.” Aiden shook his head. “The last time we managed to get information from the island, we saw an order issued by Frostholm’s authority. The order clearly stated that the hatch of the submersible was not to be opened, and any samples scraped from its outer hull had to be thrown into the incinerator after research.

“From that order, at least, we can see that the Governor of the city-state is still being cautious. But that was already several days ago. No one knows if anything has changed by now.”

“If they cannot reach a firm conclusion for a long time, and then a few dangerous, strange lab accidents happen, the wisest thing Frostholm’s authority could do would be to throw the submersible straight into the Crucible and stop all research. That is what we did back then.” Tyrian frowned. “But they are still locking down Dagger Island… That means they must be trying to dig some secret out of that submersible.”

“In theory, the higher-ups in Frostholm should know about the old Abyssal Trench Project. At the very least they should know how dangerous and terrifying the Deep Sea is.”

“Knowing is one thing. Understanding is another.” Tyrian shook his head. “Later generations can hear the stories of their elders from books and from

word of mouth, but unless they go through it themselves, it is very hard for them to imagine that kind of fear and helplessness.

“When facing an supernatural runaway state, humans’ greatest strength is that we can ‘forget’. Our greatest weakness is also that we can forget.”

Aiden glanced at his captain. After more than ten seconds of silence, he finally spoke: “Captain, should we take some more… active measures?”

“More active measures?”

“Make contact with Frostholm’s authority and warn them, or, to be more direct… have the fleet strike Dagger Island and seize that ‘No. 3 Submersible’ for ourselves,” Aiden said plainly. “With the current garrison on Dagger Island, they should not be able to withstand a strong assault from the Sea Mist Fleet.”

He paused for a moment, then added: “Otherwise, if we let those people who know nothing hammer away at a twisted replicant that floated up from the Deep Sea, who knows when they will cause a huge disaster. It is hard to feel at ease.”

Tyrian fell into a short silence.

A moment later, he shook his head. “Even if we launch a successful surprise attack on Dagger Island, can you be sure we will find the No. 3 Submersible before Frostholm’s main forces react? That island is not small. If we take too long searching, we will have to face a City Navy several times our size.

“The Sea Mist is strong, but it is not invincible. Besides…”

He trailed off. In his mind, the face of Frostholm’s Queen appeared.

The next second, Tyrian forced himself to stop his wandering thoughts—he almost let another face, identical to the Queen’s, rise up in his mind.

“It is nothing,” he said, shaking his head. “I still need to think this through.”

“Then you should make up your mind soon.” Aiden nodded. Just then, a peal of bells rang from the direction of the harbor square. The First Mate looked up toward the sound. “Ah, it’s past midnight… Captain, why don’t you go to the square and join the fun? Adjusting your mood might help you make your decision.”

“I will pass,” Tyrian refused at once, shaking his head. “I am not interested.”

“It would be good to show your face once in a while.” Aiden egged him on with some enthusiasm. “You do not get to see Badica dancers every day—their dancing is more graceful and lively than a blacktail cliff swallow crossing a storm…”

“That is exactly what I am not interested in.” Tyrian spread his hands helplessly. “And honestly, if I showed up at the gathering as the captain, would the sailors really still be able to let loose?”

“Sure they would. Why wouldn’t they?” Aiden said casually. “You know how thick their faces are—hard as iron, and they grow back after you hit them…”

Tyrian: “…”

In the end, Aiden still failed to persuade his stubborn captain. He went alone to the harbor square to join the night’s celebrations.

After midnight, Pirate Island was still boiling with noise.

The sleepless, tireless Undying had endless energy, and there were no curfew rules on this island that had been reshaped and shrouded by supernatural power. Their celebrations could last an entire day, from sunrise to sunset, and from sunset back to sunrise again.

The high platform at one side of the square had already been turned into a stage.

Temporary wooden walls blocked the cold wind from the sea, and the braziers burning around the stage pushed back the chill of the winter night —Undying no longer feared heat and cold, but the human guests who had come to Pirate Island tonight still needed careful protection.

Young maidens from Cold Harbor were dancing passionately between the bonfires and the cold wind.

Their skirts flew, the dancers spun, the bonfires snapped and leaped in the darkness, and the sound of waves rolled on ceaselessly in the distance. The terrifying Undying were roaring beneath the stage. On mist-shrouded Pirate Island, a rare, noisy veil of night had fallen over the world.

Tyrian stopped in an inconspicuous corner at the edge of the square and looked toward the stage.

He had not come to join the gathering. He was on his way back to his quarters and was only passing by.

The weekly seafarer gathering was a “custom” that had existed back when they were still part of Frostholm’s navy. Even after leaving Frostholm, this habit had been kept within the Sea Mist Fleet.

Half a century had passed. Many things had changed, and many things had not.

Watching his old subordinates making a racket in the square, Tyrian slowly showed a faint smile. Then, all of a sudden, that smile faded a little.

He looked at the stage, at the dancers upon it. Their movements were passionate, their jumps were like startled birds, but their eyes were slightly dull and numb.

They had probably drunk in advance a potion brewed from several herbs and a small amount of supernatural catalyst. It was not a rare thing.

The potion's power could let them resist the cold to a certain extent, but it also affected their awareness and thoughts.

It could keep them from feeling fear, leaving only the instinct of dance in their minds for a time.

Clearly, the masters of these dancers did not want their tools to ruin their peaceful business relations with Frost Sea's pirate leader because they were afraid.

Tyrian clicked his tongue.

This was actually very common. Anyone who dared to do business among pirates and even sent people onto Pirate Island used similar tricks. After all, the Church and The authority would not get involved in their gray trade. Ordinary people had no choice but to come up with "home remedies" to fight the shadows and horrors on the Boundless Sea.

The life of pirates and "risk-taking speculators" had never been like in adventure tales, where horror was full of romance.

In a way, forcing the dancers to drink the potion was also a kind of protection for them.

Tyrian just felt it spoiled the mood—he had thought that "Cutlass Martin" would have improved after so many years, but it turned out the man was still running his "Frost Sea entertainment business" with the same old tricks from ten years ago.

He shook his head and was about to leave.

Just as he was turning away, a faint crackling of flames suddenly reached his ears.

That strange yet familiar sound of fire made Tyrian’s heart tighten at once. He almost lost his footing. Then he stared hard toward where the sound had come from.

Pale green flames were jumping on a nearby wall covered in ice. As the light spread, the ice in the middle turned black, as dark as the veil of night, and a tall, imposing figure stepped out from within it.

“Good evening, Tyrian,” the figure said. “I hope I am not disturbing your rest.”

Tyrian stared at the figure in the ice for a long moment before he finally managed to keep his expression under control and answer the greeting: “Goo… good evening, Father. Why did you suddenly…”

“There are some things I want to discuss with you, and I also wanted to see how you have been lately,” Duncan said offhandedly. “What are you doing?”

As he spoke, he raised his head. His gaze passed over Tyrian’s shoulder and landed on the distant stage.

On the young maidens who were still wearing thin dresses in the cold wind.

“…Impressive.”

“It is not what you think!”

Chapter 311: Intelligence Exchange

An old father, worried about his children's daily life, came by to see what his son was doing at home.

His son, at half past midnight, on a frozen island base in the middle of the sea, had set up a stage so he could watch a dozen young ladies dance belly dances.

The old father suffered a mental shock.

For a moment, Tyrian was completely stunned. To be honest, his feeling of horror right now, and the waves crashing through his mind, even surpassed what he had felt a few days ago when he heard that another "No. 3 Submersible" had appeared near Frostholm.

The pirate captain, famous all across the Frost Sea, stiffly shuffled a step to the side, even trying to use this clumsy method to block Duncan's line of sight. But then another nearby ice-covered wall lit up at once, and Father simply stepped over into that mirror surface, still looking toward the stage.

"Aren't they cold?"

Tyrian answered without thinking: "…They are, but they can endure it with a special alchemical draught…"

"Tyrian." Duncan turned his eyes back, looking at Tyrian, who was now frozen in place like an ice sculpture. "Do not be so tense. You have long been an adult. You are free to have any daily hobby you like. It is just that…

this hobby is a bit beyond what I expected. Does your younger sister know?”

“It is not what you think!” Tyrian could not help shouting again—this time his voice held more helplessness, even a touch of despair. “And please do not mention this to her! If you ever get a chance to contact her in the future…”

“Oh, so she does not know.” Duncan nodded. “Indeed, it is better not to let Lucretia know about this sort of thing.”

Tyrian: “What do I have to say for you to…”

Duncan laughed.

Of course he could see the expression on Tyrian’s face and had heard what Tyrian had just cried out. He simply found it amusing—being able to see this kind of reaction on the Frost Sea’s number one pirate lord was not easy. It would be a real shame to miss such a fine scene.

The moment he saw Duncan smiling, Tyrian understood.

First, he was startled.

Father was teasing him. It was a slightly mean, yet long-lost kind of joke.

Next, he forced his shocked expression away and made his face serious again—just as if his previous loss of composure had never happened.

“If you have watched enough, then let us talk business,” the pirate lord sighed, sounding rather helpless. “I do not believe you came to see me in the middle of the night only to play this kind of joke.”

“I ran into a ship.” Duncan dropped the smile as well and spoke directly. “The Obsidian. Do you remember that name?”

“The Obsidian?” Tyrian frowned, first thinking over the well-known ships on the various routes and finding nothing, but then his expression changed. “You mean the Obsidian? I only know of one Obsidian, and it should have sunk already…”

Just as Duncan had expected.

No one knew the ships in this cold sea better than a pirate lord who had ruled the northern region for half a century. And if it was a vessel that had sunk in a sea disaster, it would leave an even deeper mark in Tyrian’s mind.

Because a ship lost to a sea disaster was seen as the worst of omens on the Boundless Sea. Captains could ignore other ships if they wished, but they would still go and find out the names of the ships that had sunk, what cargo they had carried, what they had done, and where they had gone.

“That is the one—the wreck that sank six years ago,” Duncan said with a nod. “It has appeared on the surface again, completely turned into an uncanny thing. Its cabins are twisted and jumbled together. There is living mud spread all over it, and… a ‘captain’ who is human and yet not human.”

When Duncan finished, Tyrian’s eyes had already opened wide. After a short moment of thought, the pirate lord’s face grew full of shock and solemnity.

He did not question it, because he knew his Father would not lie to him at a time like this or about a matter like this—Duncan would not do something so pointless.

Even so, it was still hard to believe. What he was hearing had gone far beyond what he had imagined.

“Does it sound familiar?” Duncan’s voice came from the ice, wrapped in the cold of the Frost Sea itself. “It is a bit like the situation with the ‘No. 3

Submersible’, only worse. That is a replica that returned from the Deep Sea. Not only the people inside, but the ship itself has been twisted.

“You took part in the Abyssal Trench Project. I want to hear your judgment.”

“My judgment…” Tyrian opened his mouth, then suddenly realized something else. “Wait. Where did you encounter that ship?!”

He suddenly remembered that the Obsidian had sunk near Frostholm. In theory, its replica should also surface in the waters around Frostholm. How did Father end up running into that ship?!

Duncan smiled faintly in the ice.

“Are you standing somewhere high enough?”

“High enough?” Tyrian looked around, confused. “The ground is fairly high here. The harbor district as a whole is on high ground…”

“Do you have any buildings blocking your view to the southwest?”

“No.”

“Good. Look in that direction and wait a bit.”

Tyrian instinctively turned to look southwest.

There was a gentle slope there, tilting slightly toward the sea. Most of the main housing in the harbor district stood along that slope. At the far end lay the shoreline. A few kilometers beyond, dense mist and chaotic currents circled the secret home port.

Something flickered inside the fog.

Pale green flames rose and shone like a ghost within the mist.

Tyrian blinked.

After a while, he heard a muffled boom—distant and hazy, yet clearly not an illusion.

That was the sound of old muzzle-loading smoothbore cannons firing.

“You are in the Frost Sea…” Tyrian felt his muscles tightening. A strange cold, subtle yet all-pervasive, seemed to be slowly wrapping around him. He hesitated, then turned back to the ice where Duncan’s figure stood. “You… found this place?”

“It was not easy. Your island is surrounded by heavy fog and drifting ice, and there are wild currents crashing everywhere,” Duncan said with a light smile. “But the Spirit Realm is calm and has safe routes.

“Do not worry, I will not sail the Vanished right up to your island. That would make your subordinates nervous. The Vanished will hide in the mist around you.”

Tyrian thought it over and suddenly felt that this last sentence was even more chilling—that was worse than just bringing the Vanished straight into the Harbor!

But in the end he did not dare say that out loud.

He was afraid that if he did, the next day when he opened his eyes he would really see the Vanished’s flagpole planted above the harbor district.

“Your expression is tense and gloomy,” Duncan’s voice came again. “Have I brought you trouble?”

“Ah, no, that is not what I meant!” Tyrian said in a rush, forcing his face to relax. “It is just that everything is so sudden, and I am still not used to… dealing with you.”

He paused, then hurried to speak again before Duncan could answer: “Why did you suddenly come to the Frost Sea? It cannot be just to give me a

‘surprise’, can it?”

“Something happened,” Duncan nodded. “A person who should have been dead for many years suddenly wrote to me from Frostholm. That caught my attention. After I arrived here, I soon saw the Obsidian again, which confirmed my guess.

“Now I suspect that the shadows left behind by the Abyssal Trench Project are starting to stir under Frostholm.”

Abyssal Trench Project…

The muscles in Tyrian’s face twitched, and many memories rose in his heart —some from half a century ago, some from much more recent days.

The news Father had suddenly brought was like a sharp blade, cutting open a Veil that had only been lifted a little before. Tyrian suddenly realized that what was happening now was far from as simple as he had thought.

It was not just a single “No. 3 Submersible”. Not just a single Dagger Island. Beneath Frostholm and the Deep Sea… it was not only the Abyssal Trench Project that was waking up.

“Your suspicion is probably correct,” he said in a low voice, his expression complicated. “Something is really going wrong under Frostholm. The Obsidian you met is not an isolated case. Do you know? Not long ago, The authority of Frostholm salvaged something in the nearshore waters.”

There was silence from the ice for a few seconds. Then Duncan spoke: “Looking at your face, I think I can guess what it was.”

“Yes. The No. 3 Submersible. The eighth replicant.” Tyrian nodded. “It has already been taken to a barren island near Frostholm called Dagger Island. The authority has turned the whole place into a military restricted zone. They want to figure out the secrets of the replicant.

“And that is not the only news. Recently, there have been rumors all over the city-state that the dead are rising. They say the dead are tearing free from their graves, and people who died or went missing many years ago have suddenly appeared on the city streets.

“But there are opposite rumors saying those people are only ordinary residents of the city-state, and that over-strained Church Guardians are just grabbing random passersby outside of curfew hours.”

Tyrian shrugged.

“Because of the tight information blockade, it is now very hard to find out what is going on at Dagger Island. As for Frostholm itself, I do have some eyes there. According to their reports, strange things really have been happening in the city lately. There are many unfamiliar faces going in and out.

“But as for the dead truly returning to life… I do not think that is very likely.”

Chapter 312: An Invitation from the Old Father

No one understood the boundary between life and death better than Tyrian and his Undying sailors.

God of Death Bartok had a gate that anchored the line between life and death. Simply put, as long as a living soul passed through that gate, it reached the world of the dead, and that gate was one-way. In other words, as long as a soul had not passed through it, then no matter if it was a brief corpse awakening or a lasting Undying curse, it did not count as a true “return from death”.

“There are many people in the world who mix up ‘Undying’ and ‘the dead’. Some even think the former slipped through a loophole in the God of Death’s gate,” Tyrian turned his head and looked at the noisy sailors in the square as he spoke calmly. “But in fact, their souls were rejected by that gate because of corruption, so they got stuck on the boundary between life and death. If you follow the strict definitions of the Church of Death, the ‘Undying’ actually still belong to the world of the living.”

Duncan did not speak for a moment. Instead, he recalled his experience in that graveyard.

He had awoken in a coffin and been called a “Restless One” by the graveyard warden. A group of Annihilators had come to steal the corpse, and they had seemed sure that the body would act strangely. Then the shell had suddenly collapsed on its own, as if it had “reached some limit”…

“Frostholm might not have seen a true resurrection of the dead, but people most likely did see the dead walking in the city,” Duncan said slowly after a moment of thought. “It is very likely that a group of Annihilators were behind these events. We just do not know how deeply they have infiltrated the place, or what they are trying to do.”

“Annihilators?” Tyrian was startled. He had not expected this matter to suddenly connect back to cultists again. “How are you sure it is related to them?”

“They once tried to take a corpse from the city-state’s graveyard,” Duncan said. “They looked well prepared, and they had even expected in advance that the body would move—although the final situation turned out to be a little different from what they expected.”

Tyrian listened in a daze. Then he looked suspiciously at his Father: “How… do you know all this? And in such detail…”

“That corpse was me.”

Tyrian: “…What?”

“Just an evening walk. I happened to run into some corpse thieves,” Duncan did not explain in detail. “That is not important. What matters is whether these so?called ‘return of the dead’ incidents are again related to that Deep Sea under Frostholm.”

“The return of the dead and the Deep Sea?” Tyrian frowned. He had never linked these two things before, and now that Father suddenly brought it up, he could not help feeling puzzled. “Why do you say that? Between these two things…”

“It is simple. The body I was ‘temporarily using’ showed a strange collapse at the end,” Duncan said. “During that collapse, its state was very similar to the ‘replicas’ you described from the Abyssal Trench Project.”

“The state during the collapse?” Tyrian sounded shocked, then confused. “But… the replicas from the Abyssal Trench Project came from the seabed more than a thousand meters down. How could the dead in the city-state have anything to do with that place…”

He stopped. His expression grew complicated and heavy. After a moment he finally looked up: “Could it be that this ‘copying’ power has already spread inside the city-state, and the cultists you mentioned are the ones pushing it? But the Annihilators should have nothing to do with the Deep Sea…”

While Tyrian muttered to himself, Duncan suddenly thought of another thing.

In the deepest part of the Obsidian, inside “Captain Cristo’s” mouth, there had been that small piece of flesh that carried the aura of the Abyssal Lord.

If that ghost ship really came from the Deep Sea beneath Frostholm, and if that Captain Cristo—whether he was a replica or the original body—had truly come into contact with the Abyssal Lord… then the Annihilators in the city-state were connected to the Deep Sea.

Tyrian looked curiously at the figure in the ice: “Father, what are you thinking about?”

“How much do you know about the Abyssal Lord? And about the Annihilators?” Duncan suddenly raised his head and asked. “How much contact have you had with them?”

“Not much contact at all,” Tyrian said. “The Annihilators are not as elusive as the Enders, but they also act low?key and move in secret. They are obsessed with studying knowledge about demons and ‘purifying’ themselves through that knowledge. They normally do not get involved with outsiders.”

Tyrian shook his head, then went on: “As for the Abyssal Lord… I have heard that His rank is equal to that of a deity, but He does not have a deity’s divine authority. In the few records that describe Him, He is a huge mass of flesh, crawling at the deepest part of the Abyssal Deep. With countless tentacles, He guards a great rift that leads to Subspace. But some say He is actually stuck in that rift, sealed there by some great power…

“Information in this area is always vague and strange,” he continued. “After all, mortals in the world almost have no way to observe the Abyssal Deep directly. All research on it is based on indirect observation of its projections in the Spirit Realm, and on soul interrogation of some Annihilators.”

Speaking of this, Tyrian could not help asking, with some curiosity: “Why did you suddenly bring up the Abyssal Lord?”

“In the deepest part of the Obsidian, I found a small piece of flesh,” Duncan said. “It is very likely from the Abyssal Lord.”

Tyrian: “…What?”

The number of times he had been stunned tonight had clearly already surpassed his old Father’s reaction earlier, when Father had seen twelve Badika dancers performing on the stage.

“I know you do not believe it, but it is true,” Duncan said. He could easily see the disbelief on Tyrian’s face. “I have a Abyssal demon with me. It can help identify it.”

Tyrian still sounded a bit dazed: “A Abyssal demon? To help identify it?”

“A Abyssal Hound—you have seen it,” Duncan said offhandedly. “Though you only saw it for a moment.”

Tyrian froze, as if he remembered something, and quickly reached up to touch his forehead.

Duncan nodded: “Yes, that one.”

Tyrian no longer knew what to say.

Duncan lifted his gaze instead, looking past Tyrian’s shoulder toward the square.

After several rounds of dancing, even the dancers who had taken potions in advance should rest.

“We should end our talk,” Duncan suddenly said. “This matter seems more complicated than either of us thought. It is hard to reach any real conclusion just by talking through a sheet of ice like this.”

“You mean…”

“I will send a messenger over,” Duncan said. “The messenger will bring you to the Vanished. There, we can talk more easily, and you can see with your own eyes what I brought out from the depths of the Obsidian.”

Go aboard the Vanished?!

Even though it sounded like a calm invitation, Tyrian still could not help feeling a sudden chill and tension.

He tried hard to control the change in his expression, but the brief flicker in his eyes did not escape Duncan.

“If you do not want to, I can also come directly,” the voice in the ice said softly. “But then you will first have to prepare your subordinates.”

Tyrian’s expression grew a bit tense.

Should he go to the Vanished himself, or let the Vanished sail into the Sea Mist Fleet’s base?

Either option felt like a challenge to his life’s limits.

But after a short weighing of the choices, he made a decision with his reason.

“Send the messenger,” he said. “It will be easier if I go over there.”

Tyrian looked calmly at Father in the ice.

Reason told him that if Father had truly regained his humanity, then even the Vanished, which had returned from Subspace, was not a deadly forbidden place in theory.

What was there to stop him from going?

If he went alone, then only he needed to prepare himself mentally. But if he let the Vanished sail straight into the home port, then he would not be the only one who needed that kind of preparation.

He only had to fight back a bit of instinctive nervousness.

“That is good,” Duncan nodded, seeming quite satisfied with Tyrian’s answer. Then he stepped back half a step, and his figure quickly dimmed and blurred in the ice. “I will leave first. There are still things I need to do. I will let you know before the messenger sets out.”

Tyrian bent slightly before the ice, which was slowly returning to normal. Only when the last trace of green flame faded did he straighten up again.

Then he steadied himself and turned to walk toward the square.

In the square, the late?night noise had not yet died down. The Undying sailors were either eating and drinking heavily or laughing and talking without restraint. Some rough men near the stage were trying to whistle at the dancers on it—but because their mouths or throats leaked air, they could only make ridiculous sounds.

On the stage, the dancers had already finished their performance. Under the supervisor’s command, they stood in a row, as if waiting for the order to

dismiss. The cold wind blew through the gaps between the bonfires and the windbreak boards. A few of the young women seemed to be trembling a little, and in their dull, numb eyes, a touch of lively expression slowly began to appear.

The effect of the alchemical potion was fading. Their normal feelings were about to return to their minds.

Two of the young women slowly showed a bit of curiosity on their faces, but in the eyes of most of them, fear was slowly appearing.

The whole square was full of strange?looking Undying. Even with mental preparation in advance, this was not a scene an ordinary person could easily endure.

First Mate Aiden ran out. He had been watching the stage the whole time. Now he went straight to the highest point in the square and, with his cracked voice, shouted at the still noisy sailors: “Break it up, break it up! The dancing is over! The ones who look the scariest, cover your faces. If you are missing arms or legs, crawl under the tables yourselves. The young ladies are leaving—clear the path beside the stage… Waylon! Get under a table! Just seeing your face makes me jump!”

The sailors in the square roared in response. Those who needed to cover their faces covered their faces, and those who needed to hide hid. They bustled about, noisy and laughing. On the stage, the dancers’ supervisor at first looked a little at a loss at the scene. Then she reacted, gave Aiden a hasty and awkward bow, and quickly led the girls down from the stage.

The girls whose faces showed tension and fear tried hard to hide behind the others as they hurried toward the temporary quarters arranged for them.

Two very bold young ladies even stopped on purpose, blinking as they looked curiously at the Undying in the square.

One girl, passing by Aiden, tilted her head up and said something to him with a bright smile. The First Mate instantly became completely embarrassed and almost fell off the platform.

The dancers from Cold Harbor left the stage.

Aiden finally noticed Tyrian, who had come into the square.

Chapter 313: Debt Cleared

Aiden jumped down from the platform and walked over to his captain. When he noticed how serious the captain's expression was, Aiden's face immediately turned solemn as well.

"Captain, what happened?"

"An invitation I cannot refuse," Tyrian looked around and then sighed. "Tomorrow or the day after, I may need to leave here for a while."

Aiden's eyes went wide at once: "A message came to the island? Just now? And… how can there still be an invitation on this Frost Sea that even you cannot refuse?"

Tyrian sighed again: "…It is my Father."

Aiden blinked and held it in for a long time before asking: "…How long will you be gone, roughly?"

"I should be back soon. One or two days," Tyrian said. He did not notice the subtle change in the First Mate's tone. His mind was full, and he truly had no extra energy for other talk. "A messenger will come to the harbor to take me to the Vanished. Do not announce this matter for now. While I am 'gone', you will take charge of everything."

Aiden lowered his head at once and accepted the order: "Yes, Captain."

Then the First Mate paused for two seconds. He seemed a bit hesitant. He could not help glancing around, then leaned closer to Tyrian and muttered: "Is he… somewhere nearby?"

Tyrian thought for a moment and patted Aiden on the shoulder: “the Vanished is hiding in the mist around us.”

He could almost see Aiden’s muscles tightening bit by bit.

“…Captain, after not breathing for so many years, I finally remember what ‘cold’ feels like today,” First Mate Aiden said, his voice now very careful. “Are you sure the old Captain… just wants to meet you?”

“I do not know, and I do not want to know. My gut just tells me this trip should be safe,” Tyrian said in a low voice. Then he looked back toward the square, at the sailors who still did not want to leave and planned to drink and gather until sunrise, before turning again to the First Mate. “But the other sailors may not see it that way. You know what I mean.”

Hearing the captain’s serious words, Aiden slowly nodded.

He knew what his captain was worried about.

The Sea Mist Fleet was huge. Aside from a few ordinary people who had been hired with money or contracts as outer members, most of the fleet’s crew were Undying like Aiden himself. Strictly speaking, these Undying sailors could be divided into two groups—

One large part were former members of Frostholm’s navy. These soldiers, who had once sworn loyalty to Frostholm’s queen, had all been ordinary people at first. Only after Frostholm’s rebellion did the loyal ones who stayed in the ranks get gradually transformed into what they were now.

In half a century of endless fighting, in constant clashes with the rebels, death and the power of the Sea Mist’s curse slowly turned them into the “Undying sailors” they were now, and made them part of the Sea Mist Fleet.

The other, smaller group of sailors were the true “original core” under “Steel Vice Admiral” Tyrian. They had once been members of the Vanished

Fleet.

Duncan Abnomar was their “old captain”. They had seen with their own eyes the Vanished’s transformation and fall. They had personally lived through this stormy century. They had once followed Tyrian in swearing loyalty to Frostholm, and then watched Frostholm itself turn upside down in great upheaval. The sailors who had been loyal for a full century were called the “First Generation”, and those who had served for half a century were called the “Second Generation”.

Aiden himself, and that half?baked old priest with a dent in his head, Will, were both members of the First Generation.

A century of experience let Aiden see many things hidden beneath the surface.

The Vanished and “Captain Duncan” did not mean the same thing to the two groups of sailors. The same news, when placed before them, would trigger reactions that were complex and hard to control.

And right now, even Captain Tyrian himself did not dare be sure what the Vanished and the “old captain’s” true state was, much less whether that state would really remain stable for long.

So before things became clear and the situation was fully under control, the news that the captain was going to the Vanished could not be spread. Otherwise, the island would definitely turn into a pot of boiling chaos.

Just then, Tyrian’s voice came again, cutting off Aiden’s thoughts: “… Tomorrow morning, send the dancers back to Cold Harbor.”

“Send them back tomorrow?” Aiden did not know why the captain suddenly brought this up. “Are you not satisfied with them?”

“The Vanished is nearby. For now, it is better not to let ordinary people come close to this island,” Tyrian shook his head, casually giving an

excuse. After all, “shocked by my own father” was not a reason he could say out loud no matter how he thought about it. He paused, then added: “But what you said just now reminded me of something. If we just send them back like this, that mean ‘Cutlass Martin’ may very well make things hard for the girls… Later I will write a letter. You give it to the dancers’ supervisor.”

Aiden lowered his head at once: “Yes, Captain.”

“Mm,” Tyrian nodded, then seemed to remember something. “Right, when I came over just now I saw one of the dancers stop and say something to you. You looked completely at a loss… What did she say to you?”

Aiden looked a bit embarrassed for a moment: “She said my head shape was very sexy…”

Tyrian silently looked at the First Mate’s shiny bald head.

“…The dancers from Cold Harbor really are passionate and bold—their temperaments are warm, and their taste is very bold.”

…

Darkness, solitude, cold, silence.

A barren plain stretched into the darkness as far as the eye could see. There were no plants and no animals, only jagged strange rocks and crumbling ruins that had weathered and rotted for who knew how many years. They lay collapsed in the gloom, silent forever. From time to time, weird lights flashed across the sky and drifted through the dark, sometimes lighting the plain, sometimes casting mottled, twisted shadows on the ground.

A hollow black figure trudged across the plain.

He did not know how long he had been walking, and he did not know the name he had when he set out. He only remembered that he had started this

journey a very, very long time ago, and the faint impression left from that time told him that he should have reached the end long ago, and should already be resting in some peaceful place.

What had delayed this journey? What had forced him to keep trudging across this plain?

The vague, hollow shadow tried to think, but soon those broken thoughts were swallowed by a greater emptiness, and he could only follow his instincts and keep walking forward.

But suddenly, his steps faltered.

Had he tripped over something? Or been bumped by something unseen?

The hollow shadow lowered his head and looked at himself. He saw that a few colors seemed to be appearing on his vague body.

He lifted his head and kept walking.

More colors appeared on him, and more solid details showed on the surface of his body, which had been rising and falling like mist.

Clothes appeared on this human?shaped black mist. It was a seafarer’s uniform.

He slowly gained a face—that of a middle?aged man with black hair.

His steps slowly became steady and light, and at some point the jagged stones under his feet had become much smoother.

More and more memories began to surface in this soul.

First came his name, then the moment of his death. After that came the bright, sunny days of his youth, the blurry, childish memories of childhood, and the tiny, warm flashes of light from when he had been in swaddling clothes.

He trudged toward the end of the plain. In the darkness, shadows of all sizes sometimes appeared and merged into him without a sound.

They seemed to be pieces that had once been torn and split off from him, now returning one by one to their proper places.

Suddenly, the figure stopped at the end of the road.

Cristo Barbelli raised his head in confusion and saw that he had somehow walked onto a great avenue. Ancient stone pillars stood silently on both sides of the road, and at its far end a huge, majestic gate, covered in old and complex patterns, rose out of thin air.

The gate stood open, but the inside stayed hazy, and he could not see any details on the other side.

Only a strong urge rose from deep inside this soul—to pass through that gate and rest on the other side.

The middle?aged man in a captain’s uniform walked forward without thinking. There was no one around him, but he felt as if countless other souls were walking this road at the same time, also heading toward that gate. Every moment in the mortal world, the dead were setting out on their way. It was just that, before this lonely gate between life and death, the souls did not seem to be able to see one another.

Yet just as he was about to touch the gate, Cristo stopped.

A tall figure suddenly appeared in front of the gate and blocked his way.

It was a warden, wrapped from head to toe in bandages, wearing a dark, ornate robe and a hood, and holding a long staff in one hand.

This was the gatekeeper here.

Cristo looked at this almost three?meter?tall “giant” with some fear. Memories from when he had been alive surged up, letting him remember

how to speak to others: “Are you… the master of death?”

“No,” the gatekeeper spoke. A hoarse, deep voice came from under the bandages. “I am only His envoy.”

Cristo sounded a little sad: “I am not qualified to cross this gate, am I?”

He remembered more things.

Including the details of his own death.

But the solemn gatekeeper only lowered his head and looked quietly at the soul at the gate for a moment. Then he moved slightly to the side: “Please, go in. Your debt is cleared.”

Chapter 314: On Dagger Island

To the east of the city-state of Frostholm, at the far edge of sight from the sea cliffs, you could see a tall rocky island. It was long and narrow, curved like a thin saber or a strange dagger. Jagged rocks and barren sand covered the whole island, so the people of Frostholm simply named it after its shape and called it Dagger Island.

On the vast, endless sea, land was the most precious foothold. No matter how barren or narrow a lonely island was, people would still try every way to make use of it. Dagger Island was no exception.

The island had fresh water, but no land that could be farmed and no ground wide or flat enough to build a real settlement. It could not serve as a stable place to live or grow grain, and it had no useful plants or animals. But the island had once held a small deposit of Boiling Gold, so the people of Frostholm built a mine and a refinery there.

When that tiny amount of Boiling Gold was finally dug out, the island served for a while as a transfer harbor. Later, after the Frostholm rebellion, the routes around the city-state were adjusted. The harbor on the island was turned into a special storage site, used to keep dangerous things that had to be kept far from the civilized world.

As the years passed and the world rose and fell, this barren, rock-covered island changed hands many times. Now it was controlled by the Frostholm military and had become a secret “temporary research base”, used to study the strange thing that had been dredged up from the Deep Sea.

The sealing apparatus used to store dangerous objects, together with the tight security on the island, gave strong protection for this kind of research.

At noon, a mechanical cutter came from Frostholm and drew near the military harbor on the hollowed side of Dagger Island. The tall flag flying on the mechanical cutter showed that it belonged to the Frostholm navy.

After a series of complicated and strict checks, tests, and registration steps, the fast ship named the Sea Swallow was cleared to dock. As the steam core's roar slowly sank to a low growl, it came to rest beside the pier and lowered a gangplank from the rail.

Several soldiers in blue-black naval uniforms walked down the gangplank first. After them came a tall, broad-shouldered officer with short gray hair.

A few military personnel stationed on the island were already waiting on the shore.

The burly officer with gray hair took in the situation around the pier, then walked ashore along the gangplank. The waiting personnel at once stepped forward and saluted. One of them said: "General, you are twenty-five minutes later than scheduled. This needs to be recorded and explained—you must go to the registry in person."

"Mm." The burly officer, the general they had called him, nodded. He did not feel that a normal officer saying this to a general like him was any kind of offense. This was a special research facility. Strict approval rules were normal and reasonable safety demands. "We will go now… How are things on the professor's side?"

"Professor Merson is in the 'Chamber'," the man who came to receive him said. "He made a discovery while running tests on the new batch of samples. Under special test conditions, the material scraped from the

surface of that thing seems to show strange properties. But the details will have to wait until we get into the ‘Chamber’.”

“All right, take me to the registry first.”

…

Not far from the military harbor of Dagger Island, on the inner side of the bay, research work was still going on in tense, busy order inside a strong building made from reinforced concrete and huge blocks of stone.

This gray, dull-looking structure was the so-called “Chamber”. It was also one of the best-protected and strongest laboratories on the island.

The hall inside the building was brightly lit.

It was a large hexagonal room. Each wall had been poured from the toughest concrete, and symbols and religious signs with meaning in occult studies were carved along the tops of the walls. Huge cloth bands covered with scripture hung down from the ceiling, crossing and overlapping in the spaces between the light of the gas lamps. Steam pipes crisscrossed above the hall. Some valves hissed softly, while incense devices burned quietly in the corners, their holy smoke slowly blending into the air.

Researchers in short robes worked busily all over the hall. In the very center, a metal device about five or six meters across, round and swollen like a Great Bell, hung from heavy chains. The surface of the metal was mottled and old, as though it had spent ages soaked in seawater. The complex valves and fittings at the top were enough to show its purpose.

It was a diving bell.

Directly under the hanging diving bell, the center of the floor held a huge circular grate. Its diameter was much larger than the long axis of the bell. Through the grate, one could faintly see a striking red glow deep underground.

A very tall, very thin old scholar with neatly combed silver hair stood in front of the diving bell, watching a few assistants carefully scrape samples from its surface.

A clergy member in priest's robes walked slowly behind the assistants. This priest carried a brass censer in his hand. Pale incense smoke rose from the brazier with a soft whisper, like a murmur of benediction, and drifted through the air.

"Professor, General Belazov has reached the harbor," one assistant came over and said from behind the tall, thin old scholar. "After he finishes the necessary registration and handover, he will come here to see you directly."

"Oh… Belazov. I got the message that he would come in person. It seems City Hall is finally getting a bit nervous." Professor Merson, whose silver hair was so neat not a strand was out of place, sounded slightly helpless. "Let him come… How are the samples that came to the lab this morning?"

"They went through the final round of tests. Now we can be sure that, even though that stuff looks like rust, it is not any material we know," the assistant answered. "And as time goes by, its properties keep changing. It feels… as if that thing is still in some kind of evolution, so it never shows a stable set of traits."

"Mm."

Professor Merson nodded slightly, but his eyes stayed on the diving bell hanging in midair.

The outside of the diving bell was badly eaten by rust, but the round hatch on its side was still easy to see. The hatch was tightly shut. From the time it was brought into this "Chamber", it had never once been opened.

On the other side of the diving bell there was a round window. A very, very thick plate of special glass was set there. For some reason, the inside of the

window was covered in filth. Black grime almost coated the whole pane, so that no one could see what was inside the diving bell at all.

They could only just make out a messy hollow space, and something that looked like liquid.

What was inside the diving bell?

Professor Merson himself had wondered this more than once. But no matter how curious he was, he never had the slightest thought of opening the hatch.

The year the Abyssal Trench Project began, he had been sixteen.

He had learned what things one could be curious about, and what things one had to treat with care.

As he thought, the assistant's voice came from behind again: "Professor, do you think the people above will order us to open that hatch?"

"Honestly, I do not want to get that order at all," Professor Merson shook his head and turned to look at his assistant. "Courage and the spirit of exploration let humans survive on the Boundless Sea. But once those two things cross the line, they turn into recklessness and death."

The assistant blinked. Then the assistant blinked a third and a fourth eye.

"But our progress is too slow—and if it is really like you said, what if another submersible comes up?"

Professor Merson thought for a moment, then slowly shook his head. "If that really happens, opening the hatch will not be all we have to do. We will have to be ready to face the Deep Sea itself."

The assistant looked as if the meaning was only half clear.

This assistant was still too young. But then again, after half a century, how many people could still understand the horror of the Abyssal Trench Project?

Professor Merson lifted his head and looked at the busy figures around the diving bell.

Some of those figures did not seem quite the same as when they had first come to the island.

Some others now and then gave the old professor a faint sense of strangeness.

It felt as if many unfamiliar figures had quietly appeared in this research facility.

But that was not strange. Personnel changes in a research team were very normal, especially in a complex, special project that needed many experts. Everything looked very reasonable.

The clergy member holding the brass censer walked over and nodded slightly to Professor Merson.

The censer in his hand opened its eyes a little and secretly studied the old scholar’s face.

The strange scent of incense drifted through the air.

“Today’s Blessing rite is complete,” the clergy member said softly. “I will come again at this time tomorrow to give a benediction to the machines.”

“Thank you for your hard work, priest %?&%@*.” The old professor smiled and nodded, calling him by name as if it were the most natural thing in the world. “If not for the pile of trouble that is sure to come this afternoon, I should buy you a drink.”

“You should greet the general first,” the priest said with a laugh. “He is the big shot sent by Frostholm to ‘watch over’ this place.”

Chapter 315: Deeply Shocked

General Belazov arrived at the Chamber.

The moment he stepped into the large building of reinforced concrete and stone foundations, the burly gray-haired soldier felt a solemn, heavy, and eerie air, as if something pressed down on him. That feeling came from the rune carvings he saw everywhere inside the building, and from the many closed doors along the halls.

The runes were part of the safety measures of this building. They were designed to resist supernatural forces from outside and keep unwelcome Visitors from entering. Behind each closed door lay a deep passage. At the end of such a passage might be the sealing room of some anomaly, or a warehouse of dangerous samples, or researchers who had fallen into a temporary madness, or ancient documents that were forbidden to touch yet could not be destroyed.

Walking inside this building felt like wandering in the crack between the Mortal Realm and a mad abyss. It felt like standing on some invisible front line, looking out at another treacherous world. Even an ordinary person with no supernatural power or gift of Spiritual Insight might feel their nerves tighten and the hair on their arms stand on end.

“…Are the safety measures here really enough to make sure ‘that thing’ does not cause trouble?”

General Belazov followed a military scholar who led the way. As they passed a black alloy gate, he could not help asking.

“The Chamber is the most secure building on Dagger Island. Every room here has its own security and supernatural barrier. Under every item with a danger level above three there is a direct shaft down to the Crucible. And even if we ignore all the supernatural barriers, this building alone, by its sheer structural strength, could withstand a full-force attack from a Saint-level enemy,” the scholar who led the way said with pride. “Unless some Elder Gods stretch their power into this place, it is absolutely safe.”

He paused, then went on: “And besides, even though ‘that thing’ feels strange in every way, it is much more ‘stable’ than we first thought. You could even say well-behaved.”

“Stable? Well-behaved?” General Belazov frowned and spoke without thinking.

“Yes, though it is not very strict to say it that way,” the scholar nodded. “That thing has been hanging in the center of the Chamber for many days. Usually, objects that strange show some sign of being ‘alive’. They affect their surroundings in one way or another. But it has never shown anything like that. It has not released any substance or leaked any power. It shows no traits beyond the dimension of the Mortal Realm. Even though the samples scraped from it have some odd physical traits, those traits are limited to the physical. Compared with most dangerous objects of the same level, it is as quiet as a rock.”

“…That is an interesting case. I will report it to the city-state’s governor.” General Belazov said it in passing.

A researcher in a blue coat came walking quickly from the other side and hurried past them. As he passed the general, he nodded to him in respect, but his steps did not slow.

From inside that blue coat came the faint sound of some soft-bodied creature squirming its limbs.

“Everyone here is in a hurry,” General Belazov said casually.

“Yes, the Chamber is like this every day—we do more than just analyze that diving bell,” the scholar guiding him said with a shrug. “We also have to monitor other things in the facility. Please do not mind everyone’s lack of manners.”

“It is fine. I do not care much about such rules,” the general said, then frowned slightly. “Is it just me? There seems to be a strange smell in here. I have smelled it since I came in. It is like the smell from some… aquatic creature.”

“This is Dagger Island’s bay—the ventilation system of the building is directly connected to the outside. It is normal to have a smell like that. Add to that the smell from disinfectant and the settling pools, and it is normal for you to smell all kinds of strange things,” the scholar said, then sighed. “We have always wanted to apply for funds to repair the vents, but the answer from above is always, ‘As long as it works.’”

The general made no comment on that. He only lifted his head and looked toward the end of the corridor.

Professor Merson was already standing at the doorway.

…

Tyrian took one last look at his coat and hair in the dressing mirror. Then he stepped away and walked over to a nearby shelf, where a few items lay.

He hesitated for a long time over what to take with him.

Should he bring his sword? His pistol? His amulet?

Weapons would likely be useless. He could not count on a single sword or pistol to keep him safe on the Vanished. Besides, he was going there as a

guest. Bringing weapons would not only show bad faith, it might even anger his father.

The amulet did not have any real effect, but bringing it might offer some comfort. However, he did not know what his father's attitude toward the Gods was now. Did his father hate them? Or just look down on them?

The greatest pirate lord on the Frost Sea was, for the first time, struggling this much over the simple act of "going out."

He was going to the Vanished—he was going back to the Vanished.

That was where he had spent his childhood. Most of the warm memories in his life were there. The parts he did not want to recall or face were also there. After staying away for a full century, he now suddenly found that he could not even imagine what he would look like when he set foot on that ship again.

Just then, the voice of his first mate, Aiden, came from outside the door and cut off Tyrian's thoughts: "Captain, are you ready?"

Tyrian frowned and shouted toward the door: "Almost. Don't rush me."

"I mean, you really should hurry," Aiden's voice came again, this time with clear tension in it. "For Her Majesty the Queen's sake… the envoy is already here!"

The envoy was already here.

Tyrian froze, and only then noticed what was odd in Aiden's tone. He hurried to the door and pulled it open.

Aiden's voice was still going: "Captain, if you don't open the door, I'll… ah, thank the heavens, you finally opened it!"

Tyrian stared at the scene in the doorway.

His loyal first mate stood there with every muscle stiff. On top of Aiden's smooth bald head stood a terrifying skeletal roc wrapped in green flames. The roc's whole body threw off fire. Flecks of spirit form flame kept falling from it, now and then landing on Aiden.

In the bird's chest, a brass spirit compass floated in midair. It was his father's property.

Anomaly-022, Spirit Realm spirit compass.

"Captain, could you please stop staring and first let this bird get off my head…" Aiden's voice shook. "These flames keep falling on me…"

The skeletal roc tilted its head, as if studying Tyrian carefully. Then it suddenly opened its beak and spoke in a strange female voice: "To Chenghua Avenue, across Twin Immortals Bridge… get on! Plenty of seats, big seats! Everyone move back a bit… peanuts, drinks, mineral water!"

Tyrian almost jumped at that string of calls. The first thought in his mind was:

[How could Father's envoy sound like this?]

Then he began to wonder what those strange phrases were supposed to mean—but no matter how he thought about it, he could not figure it out.

He did notice that Aiden was about to faint.

"Let's go," Tyrian said, shaking his head. He forced all the random thoughts out of his mind and stopped thinking about how he should face his father once he reached the Vanished. Instead, he decided to leave everything to his ability to adapt on the spot. He looked at the eerie skeletal roc. "How are we __"

Before he could finish, the huge bird stomped on Aiden's skull and sprang into the air. Then it dove down from above. With a rush of cold green flame

filling his sight, Tyrian heard a strange shout right beside his ear: “Your dad’s here!”

The next second, he felt the world spin. It was as if every sense in his body was being taken apart and put back together. Right after that, he felt himself suddenly thrown up into some great height. He rushed through darkness and cold. Time seemed to pass for a very long while, or maybe only for an instant, and then the strange dizziness and feeling of being peeled apart vanished without a trace.

The solid feel of ground under his feet returned. The darkness and weightlessness were gone. sunlight shone through thin mist and fell on his body. As his familiar five senses came back, the view before his eyes steadied and slowly became clear.

A tall figure stood right in front of him.

But it was not his father. Compared with his father, this figure was too slim. It looked more like a woman.

She looked a bit familiar.

Tyrian blinked hard and finally focused his vision, seeing the face before him clearly.

White hair fell over her shoulders. A scar marked her left eye. She was tall, strong, and beautiful.

Vanna looked at the pirate lord with a strange expression, then awkwardly turned her head to glance at a few people nearby who were obviously waiting to watch a scene.

At last she sighed and said to Tyrian: “Captain Tyrian, I know you have many ques—”

Before Vanna could finish, Tyrian suddenly stepped back half a pace and stared, wide-eyed, at the lady inquisitor in front of him.

“He shot Pland down?!”

The greatest pirate lord on the Frost Sea was deeply shocked.

Chapter 316: Going Home

The mood on the deck suddenly became a bit awkward. An unspeakable silence hung between Vanna and Tyrian. The shock on Tyrian's face had not yet faded, while Vanna was already covering her forehead with her hand.

The silence was finally broken by a voice from not far away. A few meters off, Shirley nudged Nina with her elbow and said: "See? I told you his first words would definitely be that—you owe me two scoops of ice cream."

"Fine, fine, you guessed right," Nina muttered. "Two scoops it is… I'll buy them for you when we get to Frostholm."

Shirley's eyes went wide at once: "I'm not stupid! Eating ice cream in a place that's dozens of degrees below zero? We'll wait until we're back in Pland!"

Tyrian blinked and only then noticed the other people on the deck, and how the mood here was subtly different from what he had imagined. First he saw the girl named Shirley, whom he had met once before. Then he saw, by her feet, the Abyssal Hound that had once knocked heads with him, lazily basking in the Sun. A little farther to the side stood another young lady who looked sixteen or seventeen, and an elderly gentleman with graying hair and a gentle, scholarly air.

Everyone was smiling.

Behind them were the deck, rail, masts, and sails of the Vanished.

The yellowed, broken scenes from his childhood, the memories of him and his sister fooling around, every happy and unhappy impression, seemed to float up bit by bit from some dark, forgotten cave, slowly gaining color again in the sunlight shining through the thin mist.

There were some new faces here, but this was still the ship in his memories —not the gloomy, ruined, twisted ghost ship he had first imagined.

At least, the deck still looked just as familiar.

Tyrian knew he was spacing out, and he knew he ought to say something at a time like this, but he could not stop his thoughts from wandering. He knew he had had this habit since childhood. Every time he stared off into space on the deck, Father would always appear out of nowhere and scold him from behind—

“Tyrian, what are you daydreaming about here?”

The pirate captain visibly flinched. For a moment, the confusion between memory and the Mortal Realm made his thoughts freeze for two or three seconds. Then he slowly turned around and saw a tall, imposing figure standing behind him.

It was not a phantom in a mirror, not a blurry outline seen across a distant sea full of cannon fire. They were standing face to face…

“Sorry, Father,” Tyrian blurted out. “I was a bit distracted.”

Duncan frowned slightly.

He was not sure if it was just his imagination, but in that instant he felt Tyrian’s state was somehow strange, very different from the impression left by their last few encounters, and yet faintly familiar. Soon, though, he let it go.

After all, this was their first face?to?face talk after a hundred years apart, and also Tyrian’s first time back on this ship. It was normal for him to react like this.

At the same time, Vanna, who had been silent for a long while out of embarrassment, finally spoke: “Captain Tyrian, I should explain who I am here. First of all, it is not what you think. I came to the Vanished by order of the Church…”

“By order of the Church?” Tyrian was even more confused than before. He suddenly turned his head to look at his Father: “You…”

“I did not bring down the Church—watch where your thoughts are going, Tyrian,” Duncan cut him off before he could speak, already knowing what he was thinking. “Do I need to stress it again? I am no longer an enemy of the civilized world. You should face me more calmly, not like you are on guard against some calamity that might start destroying things at any moment.”

Tyrian said: “I… I’m sorry.”

“I accept your apology—let’s talk as we walk,” Duncan waved his hand and started toward the stern. “We have a lot to discuss. Why Miss Vanna is here, what happened with the Obsidian, and that dagger?shaped island.”

Then he turned back and waved at the onlookers nearby: “Anyone not involved, go mind your own work. Stop crowding around here.”

Still a bit dazed, Tyrian followed behind Duncan toward the captain’s cabin he remembered, while Vanna walked silently on the other side.

The scenes in his memory and the sights before his eyes came together and broke apart, sometimes overlapping, sometimes clashing with sharp, jarring differences.

From the very start of his return to the Vanished, everything already seemed to have slipped away from its old track and from his expectations.

Tyrian looked around without thinking. He studied the state of the ship, searching for things that matched his memories, and also searching for a figure who, in theory, should be here.

Of course Duncan noticed his little movements: “Are you looking for Alice?”

Tyrian paused, then remembered that this was the doll girl’s name—he had always thought of her as “Ray Nora”: “Ah, yes. Is she on the ship?”

“She is, but she should be busy in the kitchen right now,” Duncan nodded. “Alice is in charge of the food on the ship. You can try her cooking today—we have fresh vegetables and fish that were just caught. You don’t often see that on an ordinary long?distance voyage.”

“The food…” Tyrian repeated the word without thinking and almost said, “So Father eats regular meals too.” The next second, a series of startled cries and hurried footsteps suddenly came from not far away, cutting off his wandering thoughts.

“Help help help help help help help——”

That was Alice’s scream.

Tyrian turned in shock toward the sound and saw that doll girl who kept calling him “brother” running across the deck not far away, shouting at the top of her lungs with a kitchen knife raised in her hand. Right behind her bounced a wooden barrel, hopping up and down. The barrel was full of carrots and greens.

Duncan watched, expressionless, as Alice ran back and forth across the deck, as Nina and Shirley rushed over to help and failed, until it turned into

three people and one dog racing around the deck, chased by a barrel of vegetables. Then he patted Tyrian on the shoulder.

“Sometimes, it gets a bit lively around here.”

Tyrian turned back with a blank look, the corner of his mouth twitching: “…Are the ingredients on this ship maybe a little too fresh?”

“It’s because of the barrel—it has its own ideas about how vegetables should be stored, so it often has… differences of opinion with Alice.”

“You don’t need to help?”

“No. Alice has a big heart.”

“But it looks like she’s asking you for help…”

“It’s fine. I have a big heart too.”

Tyrian’s expression seemed to freeze. Even as a pirate leader who commanded a whole Undying fleet, he still could not quite keep up with the Vanished’s daily pace.

Duncan was not surprised at all. He just patted Tyrian’s shoulder and said: “You need to learn to get used to it. If I helped every time Alice shouted for help, I would never get anything else done. As it turns out, her ability to adapt and her life force are both quite tough.”

Tyrian still wanted to say something, but they had already reached the captain’s cabin.

In all his childhood memories and in his memories as an adult, this had always been the most impressive place on the whole ship.

When he was a child, Father’s captain’s cabin was a mysterious and slightly scary room. He and Lucretia could fool around in most parts of the ship, but

they were strictly forbidden to step into this place. Even the kindest sailor on the ship would block the two siblings at the door without mercy.

After he grew up, Father's captain's cabin became a place that made people tense and where they had to stay serious. Even after Tyrian and Lucretia each became captains of the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star, they still felt nervous by instinct whenever they stepped inside. Here, Father drew up all his great plans of exploration. Here, he marked on the enchanted sea chart the islands and Visions newly found by the Vanished fleet. Here, he planned and directed the entire fleet. Most of the time, he and his younger sister only listened and carried out orders.

Father did not like other people's suggestions. In his memory, Father was a decisive and stubborn man.

The door opened, and the slightly dim interior, compared to the deck outside, came into Tyrian's view.

The next second, his gaze went to the edge of the chart table, to the black, eerie Goathead there.

The black Goathead, with its wooden texture, creaked as it turned. Its pair of hollow, deep obsidian eyes fixed on the visitor who had just stepped inside.

"Hello, nice to meet you for the first time, Mr. Tyrian."

Tyrian was startled and turned his head without thinking: "This is…"

"This is the current First Mate on the Vanished. You can trust him," Duncan introduced. "You can just call him Goathead."

"First Mate?" Tyrian blinked, then turned back to look at the strange "wood carving." Pushing down the odd feeling in his heart, he accepted Father's words and tried to greet it: "Hello, Goathead… Mister?"

Goathead shook its neck, as if about to say something, but the next second Duncan, very used to this, cut in first: “Be quiet. Stay silent while we are talking.”

Tyrian glanced at Duncan in surprise.

“When you talk to it, you must get used to cutting it off ahead of time—do not let it talk freely. That is my advice.”

Hearing Father’s warning, Tyrian’s expression quickly grew serious.

If even the mighty “Captain Duncan” treated this so strictly and carefully, then this Goathead really must be as strange and dangerous as it looked.

Naturally, Tyrian took Goathead to be some kind of extremely dangerous Anomaly, and keeping its mouth shut was clearly part of the sealing rules for that Anomaly…

Chapter 317: Facing Terror

Everywhere on this ship carried the colors of his memories—but the longer Tyrian stayed aboard, the more he realized that many things here were still different from what he remembered.

For example, the objects that seemed alive and ran all over the ship.

For example, the sails that had lost their solid form and now drifted around the masts like misty veils in a spirit form.

And for example, the unfamiliar First Mate in the captain's cabin—the strange carving Father called "Goathead."

He sat opposite the chart table, looking at the things in the room that were both familiar and not. Many of them still matched his memories, only now they carried many mottled traces of time. Father sat across from him, talking about what had happened between the Deep Sea Church and the Vanished. The Inquisitor from Pland sat by Father's side, adding details from time to time.

The way things had changed was far beyond what he had expected.

"A… Secret Envoy," the pirate lord repeated the term Vanna had just used. His tone was strange and his expression was subtle. "The Church is acting… with more boldness than I imagined."

"To be honest, it surprised me at first too," Duncan said with a smile. "That Pope is a… very hard person to read. I do not know how much of what she says is from her true heart, and how much is for the Church's interests and

under the guidance of the storm Goddess Gamona. But in any case, how this matter has developed fits what I wanted—I do need a bridge who can talk with the Churches of the Four Gods, and a helper who is good at dealing with cultists."

"Dealing with cultists…" Tyrian showed a thoughtful look. "I still remember you mentioned those Annihilators, and the clues you found on the Obsidian…"

"Bringing you here is exactly for this," Duncan nodded lightly. Then he took out the tobacco tin from his clothes, opened the lid, and showed what was inside to Tyrian. "This is the clue I found deep inside the Obsidian—the flesh of the Abyssal Lord."

Tyrian held his breath. He knew that with Father here it should not be dangerous, but at the moment the box opened he still felt a bit tense without meaning to. Right after that, he saw the "chunk of meat" inside, only the size of a thumb.

An unspeakable fear and sense of rejection rushed up in his heart almost at once. It was like the instinctive bristling of hair when a person, unarmed, suddenly met a wild beast in a narrow path. The lump of flesh only lay lifeless in the metal box, yet he still felt as if he were being stared at, locked on by some living existence with huge power and a towering will!

Tyrian almost snapped his gaze away at once. When he came back to himself, he realized that cold sweat was already running down his forehead.

"Are you all right?" Duncan noticed his state and frowned a little. "Why is your reaction even stronger than Morris and Vanna's?"

Still shaken, Tyrian blurted out: "They didn't react this strongly?"

"We felt resistance and danger, but it wasn't that intense," Vanna said at once from the side. "What did you feel just now?"

Tyrian calmly told them what he had felt in that brief moment. Then he frowned at the piece of flesh again as countless thoughts rose in his mind.

“I don’t know if it’s my imagination, but I kept feeling this thing… was staring at me just now,” he said. “As if it were still alive… or something ‘behind’ it was casting its gaze here.”

Duncan and Vanna exchanged a glance at once.

Bringing Tyrian here had indeed been the right choice. Without actual contact, some clues in the details really would have been hard to bring to light.

This piece of flesh, suspected to be a fragment of the Holy Lord, showed a special reaction to Tyrian’s approach and gaze!

“Could it be because you took part in the Abyssal Trench Project back then?” Duncan thought for a moment and spoke his guess. The Abyssal Trench Project was, as far as he could see, the biggest special factor in Tyrian’s past connected to this matter.

Tyrian did not speak for a moment. After recalling and thinking for a few seconds, he raised his head: “Can you be sure that the Obsidian really went to the Frostholm Deep Sea?”

“I can’t, because there is no direct proof. But my intuition tells me it returned from there,” Duncan said honestly. “The traits the ship showed are far too much like the ‘replica’ you described.”

Tyrian said nothing for a while. He only stared at the small black iron box on the table, as if weighing and hesitating. After who knew how long, he suddenly spoke: “Can you let me look at it one more time?”

“Are you sure?” Duncan looked into Tyrian’s eyes. “This could be dangerous. If it really was the Abyssal Trench Project that made you and

this thing connected, then every contact you have with it will only strengthen that link."

Tyrian stayed silent for two seconds, then suddenly showed a slight smile: "…On your ship, things shouldn't get as bad as they possibly could, right?"

"…If something really does come out, I will deal with it," Duncan nodded slightly and pushed the small tin box, which he had just taken back, toward Tyrian again. "Act carefully. Give a warning at once if anything happens."

Tyrian nodded, took a light breath, and again fixed his gaze on that piece of flesh from the Abyssal Lord.

Almost in the blink of an eye, that feeling of rejection and tension rose in his heart again. The sense of being gazed at from afar by a towering existence slammed hard into his senses. The link built by an supernatural power washed over his mind like a huge storm wave. His survival instincts almost made Tyrian shut his eyes at once.

But this time, he forced himself to fight his instincts. He did not look away, and he did not try to break or push back the will that was rising in his mind.

And in this longer stretch of holding on, he finally confirmed what he had only vaguely sensed before—

The will and power coming from this "Holy Lord's flesh"… actually held no malice.

All the fear, danger, and rejection he felt came only from the natural awe brought on by such a vast power. The gaze hidden on the other side of the flesh… was actually just a pale, exhausted look.

Tyrian's heart stirred. He raised his head, ready to tell Father what he had found.

Yet in the next second, he found that around him was only dark chaos—the familiar cabin and the people in the room had vanished from his sight at some point.

He stood up in shock and reached for a weapon by instinct, only to realize that he was unarmed. He carefully looked around, trying to see things in this dark chaos, but it felt as if a black veil covered his sight. Even when he held his hands in front of his eyes, he could only see vague shapes.

There was a strong mental interference. Something was using mental guidance to disturb his consciousness.

But he still did not feel any malice.

Tyrian stood in the darkness, a little lost. Suddenly, he thought he heard a sound.

There was a faint rustling behind him. Something huge was moving. A slightly cold breath drew close to the back of his neck.

Tyrian’s heart tightened at once, and he whipped his head around.

A huge, strange limb stretched out toward him in the dark, black?brown with faint blue lines running through it.

The limb was like a tentacle, yet it was hundreds of meters long. It lifted in the darkness like a soft pillar. The shapeless bulge at the end of the tentacle came to less than a meter from Tyrian’s face. Farther away along that limb, in the direction the tentacle stretched from, an even larger, even more unspeakable structure was slowly rising out of the dark!

It was like a mountain, like a city, like some twisted thing that could drive a mortal mad in an instant. It almost should not have been shaped by the world of the Mortal Realm at all, nor could it be any God’s creation made in a sane mind. It was like some soft?bodied creature from the Deep Sea, like a mix of sea star and squid, but in the next second its smoky, mist?like

surface surged. Countless more tentacles, limbs, eyes, and throats grew from it, and they changed without end.

In that short moment, Tyrian's eyes were open as wide as they could go. A roaring storm of thoughts shook in his head. He did not even know if he felt fear right now, and for a time he could not judge his own emotions at all. He only stared as the tentacle stretched toward him and gently waved in front of him, as if it wanted to talk to him, to pass on some message. But he could not understand any of it in that mountain?high, sea?like flood of information and roaring.

Eyes opened on the surface of that tentacle—many, many eyes. Tyrian met those eyes, and suddenly he seemed to finally "hear" some message he could understand from them, and from the huge, mountain?like "body" in the distance—

"…Run."

Boom!

A terrifying roar exploded in his mind. It felt like some huge repelling force was tearing his spirit loose and hurling it back into the Mortal Realm. Tyrian almost blacked out on the spot. Just as he thought his soul was about to be torn into pieces in this endless dark chaos, a dim green flame suddenly appeared in his sight.

The flame rushed toward him with a howl and wrapped tightly around him.

All the horrifying images vanished in the fire.

Before he could react, those terrible "visions" and sounds had already faded like a dream—he was back in the captain's cabin of the Vanished.

Chapter 318: Gradually Warped

For the next whole minute, Tyrian stayed sunk in the brief confusion and dullness brought on by that huge impact. His eyes could hardly focus. Countless noises surged in his mind, and his thoughts rose and fell like a lone boat in a storm—but even so, his reason stayed clear.

He knew it was those spirit form flames that had appeared in the darkness that had guarded his mind, keeping it from being corrupted by the power of the Abyssal Lord.

After a while, he slowly managed to steady his breathing. Since he had not suffered too strong a mental corruption, the visions in his head faded quickly. At the same time, he heard a calm voice from the other side: “Looks like you’ve recovered.”

Tyrian lifted his head and looked at the tall figure on the far side of the chart table: “Just now… you were the one who pulled me out?”

“You stared at it for too long. Vanna said you were falling into a nightmare,” Duncan said casually. “Luckily, I’ve been doing a bit of research on this whole ‘Dreamwalking’ state recently.”

“Nightmare…” Tyrian rubbed his brow without thinking. “Did I really look like I’d fallen into a nightmare just now…”

“It sounds like you had quite an unusual experience?” There was some curiosity in Duncan’s tone.

He had indeed made an emergency entry into Tyrian's mental world just now, but it had been different from what he usually saw after using the power of walking the Spirit Realm to enter someone else's dream. This time, after he intervened, he had not "seen" anything at all. Tyrian's "nightmare" had been nothing but darkness.

It seemed the "source" that had created the nightmare had already left before his arrival. That only made him even more curious about what had just happened.

"I… met an existence that is hard to put into words," Tyrian said with effort as he recalled what he had seen. He carefully described the images. "I can't give its exact form, and I don't dare recall all its details, but I suspect it was the Abyssal Lord…"

Tyrian told them everything he had seen and heard in that darkness, and added many details about what he had felt in his own spirit. Aside from being unable to clearly recall the full outline of that mountain-like mass of Shadows, he held nothing back.

After listening to Tyrian's account, Duncan frowned at once: "You're saying that being, which was most likely the 'Abyssal Lord,' said only one sentence to you, and it was to tell you to 'run'?"

"Strictly speaking, it was the only sentence I could understand," Tyrian said, spreading his hands. "It seemed to say a lot to me, but everything was drowned in the huge noise. In the end it seemed to give up and picked the shortest word. I only barely heard that word…"

Duncan sounded thoughtful: "So when a person's inspiration is too high, they actually can't hear the Elder Gods' muttering…"

Tyrian did not react at first. "Father, what did you say?"

“Ah, nothing. It has nothing to do with this,” Duncan waved a hand and turned his attention back to the matter at hand. He thought for a moment, then looked at Vanna. “Do you think Tyrian met the Abyssal Lord? Do you think it told him to ‘run’ in order to protect him?”

“From Captain Tyrian’s description and his own feelings, even if it was not the Abyssal Lord, it was at least some kind of heretic deity,” Vanna answered at once. “But as for what that word ‘run’ meant… I am sorry, Mr. Duncan, I don’t dare make a rash judgment.”

She paused, feeling that answer was not responsible enough, then added: “Information on the Abyssal Lord has always been scarce. Even the data held by the four great Churches is limited.

“The mainstream view at present is that the Abyssal Lord is a huge single entity at the very center of the Abyssal Deep domain. It has no ability to move and does not actively project power into the Mortal Realm. It cannot communicate and seems not to think at all. It is like…”

Vanna tapped her temple, as if struggling to find the right word to describe such an existence. Seeing this, Duncan spoke offhandedly: “Like a lump of slime mold sunk in the Abyssal Deep, down in the Deep Sea? Alive and huge, but just a clump of fungus that doesn’t think or move?”

“…You might be the only person in the world who would describe the Abyssal Lord as slime mold,” Vanna said with a strange look, but she still nodded slightly. “Yet it is indeed as you say. If the information we wrung out of those demons’ souls and from the cultists’ mouths is correct, the Abyssal Lord is such a ‘silent heretic deity.’

“The only thing it does is constantly divide more Abyssal demons from its body, or absorb those Abyssal demons that die in their fights.”

Duncan could not help rubbing his forehead. “…Why does that sound exactly like some kind of fungal carpet tumor…”

The captain was talking in that incomprehensible “Subspace dialect” again.

But Vanna was already used to this. She skillfully ignored the words she did not understand and naturally let the topic go on: “Overall, the Abyssal Lord can actually be considered a relatively harmless heretic deity, because at least it has never shown any tendency toward corruption of the Mortal Realm.

“But even so, in the classification used by the Churches of the Four Gods, it is still placed in the category of ‘Eldritch Gods.’”

“So regardless of any subjective will, its very existence is a danger?”

“Yes. Whether it’s the Abyssal demons split from its body, or those Annihilators who sign pacts with the Abyssal demons and go mad in spirit, all of them are mortal enemies of the civilized world.”

Duncan did not speak. He fell into thought for a while.

For some reason, what he thought of at that moment was the “Black Sun” that had supported the False Corona and hung dying in the flames.

But he only made that connection in passing and did not make any judgment on the true nature of the Abyssal Lord. The reason was simple: he did not have enough evidence. He would not draw casual conclusions about something he had not personally come into contact with.

Tyrian rubbed his brow. All the noise in his head had faded. What remained was only a faint dizziness and a tiredness like he had stayed up several nights in a row. While Vanna talked about the information on the Abyssal Lord, he also had his own thoughts.

“No matter whether that word ‘run’ showed goodwill or not, one thing is certain. The condition of the Obsidian was clearly the result of being affected by the Lord’s power. Now Annihilators are already active in the Frostholm city-state, and they are most likely here because of this,” Tyrian said slowly. “If the influence I just suffered really has something to do with those who took part in that plan back then, then now even the Abyssal Trench Project has been pulled into it.

“Pushing the logic further, I think what we most need to pay attention to now is that ‘Dagger Island.’ It is the lingering aftershock of the Abyssal Trench Project that has continued to this day since half a century ago.”

“The eighth ‘Number Three Submersible,’” Duncan said in a low voice. “How much do you know about the situation on Dagger Island?”

“That place is now a military forbidden zone. Even with the strength of the Sea Mist Fleet, we can’t easily get close,” Tyrian said. “The Vanished should be able to force a landing by relying on its special nature, but even then it wouldn’t be easy to find that Submersible in a short time. The island is large, the research facilities are complex, and in a serious emergency the military personnel on the island might simply order it destroyed…”

The more Duncan listened, the more wrong it sounded. He quickly cut off the pirate lord: “Stop, stop. When did I say anything about charging straight in?”

Tyrian froze, then understood at once. “Sorry, Father, I thought…”

Duncan waved his hand, signaling that there was no need to explain. “Forget that. Just tell me in general what you know about Dagger Island’s situation. It might come in handy.”

“All right. About that little island…”

…

Belazov looked seriously at the diving bell hanging in the middle of the hall.

He had already been in this research facility for two days, and during those two days he had spent half his time in this hall, dealing with this diving bell.

He was not a professional researcher. He did not understand mechanical matters, and he did not know what meaning the long string of physical and chemical tests the scholars ran on the samples had.

He stayed here for one reason only: this mechanical device, wrapped in an air of mystery and with such a strange background, had stirred up his curiosity.

An irresistible curiosity.

As a Frostholm native not yet forty years old, he had not personally lived through that great event half a century ago. But as one of the upper officials of the city-state, he at least knew about the Abyssal Trench Project from the classified files.

The Number Three Submersible took the most important place in all those files. It was the part of the entire Abyssal Trench Project that made people’s skin crawl the most.

It was covered in rust. Filth filled both its inside and outside. It hung obediently from an iron hook like a chunk of scrap metal and looked very ordinary.

Professor Merson stood beside the General and explained the safety measures of this laboratory.

“…The sling below leads straight down to the Crucible. If an emergency happens, the hook will release at once. The Submersible will smash through the grating and fall into the Crucible.

“If, after the release device is triggered, the Submersible still doesn’t fall into the channel, a linked mechanism will start. This entire room will unhook from the ‘sealed chamber’ frame and slide along a chute into a cave behind the bay. That cave is filled with nitroglycerin.”

“And the people in the lab?”

“We have thirty seconds to evacuate. After that, the evacuation passage will lock,” Professor Merson said. “But if it really is the worst-case scenario… the highest person in charge, which is me, can also choose not to open the evacuation passage.”

Belazov gave a small nod and slowly walked to the front of the diving bell.

He looked at the round glass window covered in grime and curiously peered inside.

Murky dark red sludge churned faintly inside the Submersible. Something shaped like an eyeball pressed up against the window. Through the gaps between the smears of filth, it met Belazov’s gaze.

After a long moment, the General drew back his eyes. “It’s pitch-black inside. I can’t see a thing.”

“Yes. We haven’t opened its hatch yet,” Professor Merson nodded. “Naturally, we can’t clean its interior either.”

General Belazov smiled. “That is how it should be.”

—

Chapter 319: Hidden Shadows

Belazov finished his inspection of Dagger Island and his supervision of the research work. Now, this military representative had to leave.

By the pier near the Harbor in Dagger Island's bay, Professor Merson had personally come to see him off. The old man looked up at the Sea Swallow as the ship made ready to depart.

Seamen were boarding. Harbor officials were checking the paperwork. Clergy in robes walked near the mooring lines with censers in hand. They gently swung the censers and offered prayers for the ship's mechanical parts.

The weather was clear today. It was a good day to set sail.

Belazov stood on the dock, watching group after group of sailors return to the Sea Swallow. Then he turned back to Professor Merson and said: "Professor, I'm impressed with your work here, but I still have to remind you of something—the progress on Dagger Island is slow. Some people back in the city-state are already getting impatient."

"The orders I received were to, under the premise of safety, figure out all kinds of properties of that Submersible, try to decode its material composition, and at the next stage try to understand how it appeared," the old professor said calmly. "We're moving forward according to the schedule.

"If the big shots in the Government Office really have ideas, they can try to find the blueprints the Frostholm Queen left and build a Number Four or

even a Number Five Submersible. Sending someone straight down is a lot more convenient than scraping samples in the lab every day."

"They're not going to like that answer—but I'd be very happy to pass it on for you," General Belazov laughed. "They won't have the nerve to build Submersibles. Their expressions will be even more interesting."

Professor Merson shrugged. After a short silence, his tone became a bit complicated. "Even though we joke like that, to tell the truth, I'm also worried about the progress."

Belazov did not speak. He calmly watched this old professor who had lived through the "Queen's era."

"Day after day of scraping samples and analyzing their physical and chemical properties is certainly a necessary part of standard research," the old professor sighed. "But you saw it yourself. What we can get from those samples is very limited.

"Even if we someday really open that hatch, we probably still won't draw many more secrets from the Submersible. The real secret isn't here, General. You know what I mean."

"…It's down past a thousand meters, Professor. Your ideas are a little dangerous."

Professor Merson sighed. "I thought a soldier like you would be more inclined toward dangerous ideas than a scholar like me."

"My duty is to protect the city-state's safety. That mission makes me lean toward a cautious and conservative way of doing things," Belazov said lightly. "So, you actually have some intention of restarting… those 'diving apparatus'?"

"What you really want to say is 'restart the Abyssal Trench Project,' isn't it?" The old professor gave a short laugh and shook his head. "Relax. I'm

not that reckless yet.

“But there’s a fact we can’t avoid. The key to this whole matter lies in the deep water, and a diving bell replica sitting in a lab can’t unlock any mysteries. We might really need to think about a ‘reserve plan.’

“It doesn’t have to be an active descent, but if a ninth or even a tenth replica really floats up to the surface, we should at least have some ways to respond.”

“…I’ll pass your suggestion to the Government Office,” Belazov said after a brief pause and a light breath. “Before a clear order comes down, the sealed chamber project will go on as usual.”

The old professor nodded. “Thank you.”

The Sea Swallow left.

The steam-powered fast ship cut through the gentle waves, leaving a spreading wake across the Boundless Sea. Dagger Island’s steep and winding coast slowly shrank in the distance and soon sank into the thin mist so common over the Northern Seas.

On the deck, Belazov withdrew his gaze from the island and turned toward the captain’s cabin.

Although Dagger Island was not far from Frostholm’s main island, the voyage would still take several hours. During this boring trip, he needed to organize his thoughts and carefully consider how to report the matter of the Number Three Submersible to the city-state’s administrators—and how to mention Professor Merson’s final suggestions.

The Abyssal Trench Project… This old case from half a century ago had left an influence so deep and terrifying that it had slowly turned into a taboo people did not even question. But now, new replicas had already begun

surfacing from the Deep Sea. They probably truly should take more active measures.

A seaman was waiting near the captain's cabin. He nodded to the General and reported: "The steam core is running normally. We'll arrive at Frostholm's First Harbor in four hours."

Belazov gave the somewhat unfamiliar seaman a glance and nodded lightly. "I need to rest for a while. Don't disturb me unless something important happens."

"Yes, General."

Belazov returned to the captain's cabin and sat down at the desk. He listened to the low mechanical sounds coming from deep under the floor and let out a quiet breath.

Soon, he would be back on the main island.

He steadied himself, opened the desk drawer, and took out the notebook he had placed in the hidden compartment ahead of time.

This trip to Dagger Island had brought no Anomaly, and the return voyage was also going smoothly, but some procedural matters still could not be skipped. That was an order, and also his duty.

He opened the notebook. The first line on the page came into view:

"Even if everything is normal, you must confirm your own sanity and judgment. Even if there is nothing suspicious around you, you must still verify the following content."

Belazov turned the pages and carried out a series of steps with great skill.

The sound of turning paper kept echoing through the room—

"You are left-handed. Confirm this now…"

“Recall a color, then turn to the next page… It should be blue or black.”

“Keyword: dagger. Imagine it. Confirm whether the image in your mind matches the picture on the next page.”

“Your name is Belazov. Try to spell it once in the blank space on the next page.”

“For this departure, the accompanying personnel have been reduced. There are exactly thirty-two people on the ship, yourself included. If the headcount is clearly off, immediately conduct a roll call.”

“The deputy you brought this time is Benjamin Yorden. He has a burn scar by his right eye.”

Belazov kept turning the pages and doing the simple checks or subconscious repetitions. Suddenly, his movements stopped.

His gaze rested on the last line on the page.

“A burn scar by his right eye…” Belazov silently repeated the sentence. A strange doubt floated up in his mind.

Right eye?

He slowly closed the notebook and put it back into the hidden compartment. His expression stayed calm as he stood up and pushed open the cabin door.

“Benjamin!” he called his adjutant’s name.

A middle-aged officer quickly stepped out of a nearby room and came up to Belazov.

“General?”

Belazov looked at Benjamin’s face.

At the center of that face was his eye. One eye, and only one.

A faint sense of wrongness thumped in his heart. Belazov's rational mind told him that something about what he was seeing was not right, yet a hazy Veil seemed to drape over his thoughts. He could not say exactly what the problem was, and everything still felt very reasonable.

That faint deviation in his awareness made the General grow more alert. He stared at Benjamin for a long time, trying hard to find the source of his unease, until the adjutant's voice sounded again: "General? Is something wrong?"

"…Benjamin, how many eyes should a person have?" Belazov suddenly asked.

The adjutant froze at once, as if his mind went blank at the question. Seeing this, Belazov spoke quickly: "Forget that question. I just asked without thinking—go back to your room and rest. I'll go take a look below."

The adjutant blinked. Although he was puzzled, he still nodded. "Yes, General."

The one-eyed human named Benjamin returned to his room, and he did not seem to show any Anomaly. Belazov watched his back. First he let out a breath, then turned around and quickly walked toward the end of the corridor.

He knew he had been a bit reckless just now. Once he already had doubts, he should not have asked such a strange question of someone who seemed "not quite right," even if that person was one of the adjutants he trusted most.

But without that question, he could not have confirmed whether the oddness he had faintly sensed really existed.

Now, he had his confirmation.

Something was wrong on this ship. Some… hidden, dangerous thing had come aboard.

He hurried along the corridor and reached the seamen’s mess.

The mess was full of sailors. The soldiers all looked tense and confused at the sudden appearance of the General.

Belazov’s gaze swept over every person there. Then he waved to them and quickly headed for the bridge.

There were people here as well.

There were many people on the deck too.

For this trip, the Sea Swallow’s personnel had been reduced. There had been exactly thirty-two people aboard when they left, including himself.

The number was wrong. Very, very wrong.

Yet the thought that “everything is normal” kept jumping around in his mind, as if fighting against that sense of wrongness that now lay plainly before him.

Belazov stood at the stairs leading down to the engine room, his expression calm as he cast his gaze down the sloping passage.

His torn awareness was still struggling, but he no longer needed to care about the fine differences between the two forces in his mind.

There were still more than two hours until they reached Frostholm’s main island.

The ship was sailing in a straight line toward the city-state.

He took a slow breath and stepped down toward the engine room in the deepest part of the ship.

Chapter 320: Protocol Twenty-Two

The last corridor leading to the engine room was hot and dim. The endless mechanical vibrations and roaring sounded as if they wanted to drill into a person’s skull. The lights on the walls seemed to have trouble with the air currents, and the flames inside their glass covers shook and flickered.

But all of this was nothing compared to the growing sense of wrongness and tension pressing down on him, and the dizziness from his thoughts slowly tearing apart.

Belazov controlled his steps and controlled his expression.

The closer he came to the deepest part of the Sea Swallow, the more he forced his stride to stay steady, his face as calm as usual.

Several crew members were standing in the corridor talking. They wore strange leather “coats”. The skin on their faces folded in heavy wrinkles, and their voices sounded like a low buzzing noise.

Belazov walked toward them. His mind told him that these crew members were soldiers under his command, but he could not remember their names at all.

“General?” One soldier stepped up, looking at Belazov with curiosity. “Do you have any orders?”

“I’m just here to check on the engine room,” Belazov answered this unfamiliar soldier with a calm face. “Stay at your posts.”

The soldier looked at him, then saluted and stepped back. “Yes, General.”

Belazov walked through them with his usual steady stride. He could feel those soldiers' eyes rest on him for a moment, but they soon turned away.

Were they really his soldiers? Were they really crew of the Sea Swallow? Or were they that hidden thing? Or some kind of servants? Had they noticed something? Or were they already on guard? In the next second… would these soldiers whose names he could not remember suddenly throw themselves at him?

Belazov pushed all these thoughts down into his heart. He kept them buried until he reached the entrance to the engine room and opened the unlocked gate.

Even harsher machine noise rushed out to meet him.

The steam core was running at full power. Inside the spherical container, amazing, surging force was brewing. The complex pipe system hissed along the ceiling of the engine room. Huge connecting rods and gears were spinning quickly in the steel frame at the far end of the chamber.

The machine was running very "happily" – so happily it almost felt manic.

It was as if a restless soul was pushing those heavy steel gears into a wild spin, driving the ship at its limit toward the cities of the civilized world.

Even the hissing from the steam pipes seemed to be mixed with vague, whispering voices.

Belazov's body swayed a little, but he quickly steadied himself and walked toward the steam core.

A priest stood before the valves, swinging a censer. He suddenly turned his head and looked at the General who had just stepped into the engine room. The Church badge on his chest seemed to be stained with oil, making the holy symbol on it blurred and unclear.

“General?” The priest looked at him with curiosity. “Why did you suddenly come here? This place…”

“I came to take a look… at the state of the steam core,” Belazov said, and his gaze fell on the censer in the priest’s hand.

The little ball of flesh hanging there swayed gently in the air. A pale eye opened on its surface.

He raised his head again and looked at the running steam engines and the hissing pipes.

The steam leaking from the pipes carried a faint red tinge. The edges of the rapidly spinning gears were blurred and twisted. It seemed something was living inside this huge system of machinery, and its malicious soul had replaced the holy steam that should have been there.

The machines were already under corruption. They were in a state of desecration – this thought rose in Belazov’s mind for a second, then was blown away like smoke.

Even so, he still walked toward the control console of the steam core. Even though this huge “steel heart” now looked completely normal to his eyes, he slowly reached out his hand toward the controls.

“General,” an artificer with oil on his clothes suddenly walked over from the side and raised a hand in front of the control levers. “Please don’t touch these. Machines are sometimes very fragile.”

Belazov lifted his head and gave the artificer a look.

The artificer only met his gaze calmly.

Then, all of a sudden, the artificer’s lips moved slightly.

Belazov frowned a little and read several words from the movement of those lips:

“The machine is possessed. It cannot be shut down or destroyed.”

Belazov froze for a moment. Then he saw the artificer turn sideways. While the man adjusted the levers, his lips continued to move, very slightly.

“The priest cannot be trusted… the situation is in a runaway state… Protocol Twenty-Two.”

Protocol Twenty-Two?

Belazov’s heart tightened, but soon he knew what he had to do.

The artificer understood the ship’s “heart” better than anyone.

He turned and left the engine room. He did not go to any other compartment. After leaving the lower corridor, he kept his calm posture and went straight back to his captain’s cabin.

On the way, soldiers stepped up from time to time to greet him. Some gave him a faint sense of familiarity. For others, he could not even recall their names.

There had to be clear-minded, normal humans among these soldiers. But Belazov had no way to tell who they were, and no time to contact or test the thirty humans on board one by one, not counting himself and the artificer.

He locked the cabin door from the inside, went to the safe beside his desk, and began to turn the dial. With the crisp clicks of the lock, his fingers turned even paler from the force he used.

With a soft sound, the latch opened and the safe door swung aside.

Belazov’s gaze slid past the compartment that held documents and settled on the Red Button at the bottom of the safe.

Beside the button, a small line of words was written: Protocol Twenty-Two, for use only in extreme situations.

Belazov reached out toward the button – and at almost the same moment, he heard a knock at the door: “General, are you in there? We have received orders from Frostholm that require your personal handling.”

It was his adjutant’s voice.

A trace of doubt suddenly rose in Belazov’s heart.

What if he was wrong?

What if there was nothing wrong with the ship at all, and the only problem was himself? What if he had suffered a mild corruption that caused his thoughts and memory to twist, that made him hear things and see things that were not there along the way… If that was true, then he was about to bury everyone on this ship because of his own frayed nerves.

“General, are you in there? We have received orders from Frostholm…”

The knocking grew slightly more urgent than before.

But in that knocking, Belazov suddenly woke up. He suddenly realized that those thoughts did not really match his own nature. He was not someone who would hesitate at the very last step of an action.

Someone was pouring “impurities” into his thoughts.

“That damn heretic scum!”

Belazov no longer felt even a trace of doubt. He pressed the Red Button at once.

After a very short delay, a terrible explosion swept through the entire ship. The mechanical cutter Sea Swallow was suddenly wrapped in flash and flame. Under the horrifying force of the high explosive, it was torn into pieces.

The burning wreckage of the Sea Swallow floated on the sea for a while. Driven by the currents, it drifted slowly toward the waters north of Frostholm. Then its floating finally reached its end. The red-hot wreckage began to sink faster, as if dragged down by some invisible power. Its speed grew quicker and quicker, until it vanished completely from the surface.

…

At the same time, in the city-state of Frostholm, near Cemetery No. 3, an Old Caretaker in a pitch-black coat, his back slightly bent, was slowly walking back from the city.

He had just gone to buy some daily necessities on a nearby street. It was now close to dusk, and he had to return to his “post” before the shift change.

The road leading to the cemetery was deep and quiet. Few people walked there, but even so, a resident from the nearby blocks would sometimes pass along this path.

Whenever they noticed the Old Caretaker’s figure, they would unconsciously adjust their steps and keep a bit of distance from this hunched, gloomy old man.

They did not hate this warden. They simply felt a natural fear. It was not only because the area around the cemetery was eerie and strange, but also because of the old man’s lonely and cold nature. Even in the whole cemetery district, compared with the other wardens who were more or less gloomy, the Old Caretaker of Cemetery No. 3 could be called the most frightening of them all.

He had held this post for so long that even he seemed to have taken on a bit of the air of the dead.

That had even given rise to some frightening rumors. People often said they had seen pale lights floating above the fence after nightfall, and that those lights were the warden’s soul, long separated from his body. Others said that this terrifying old man lay down in a coffin at midnight, stopped breathing with the dead, and woke again only when the Sun rose the next day.

These eerie, chilling stories wrapped themselves around the cemetery and its warden. Yet the strange, withdrawn warden seemed to never care. In fact, he almost never dealt with the nearby residents. Aside from trips like today to buy the things he needed, he spent most of his time in the small warden’s hut inside the cemetery and usually only dealt with the Church’s corpse-bearers.

He saw nothing wrong with this.

Keeping the living away from the world of the dead, so the first would not suffer harm from too much curiosity, and the second could enjoy peace after death and take their last road in quiet – that was his responsibility.

He guarded the cemetery, and he guarded the city outside the cemetery as well.

The old man raised his head and looked toward the cemetery gate not far away, then stopped walking.

Today, something was a little different.

There was a small guest.

Chapter 321: A Snowy Day

A small figure stood at the cemetery gate. It was a girl of about eleven or twelve, wearing a dark brown wool coat and a black skirt, with warm little winter boots and thick gloves. She seemed to have been waiting at the gate for a long time. Snow had started falling over Frostholm in the evening. A fair amount of snowflakes had already gathered on the gray knitted cap on her head, and faint warmth rose from her in the twilight snow.

The girl lightly stamped her feet where she stood and sometimes leaned forward to look down the slope opposite the cemetery. When she saw the warden appear, she broke into a smile at once and waved hard in his direction.

“…Here she is again.”

The Old Caretaker could not help muttering when he saw the girl. There was a trace of impatience in his tone, but he still quickened his pace a little and walked up to her.

“Annie,” the old man said, frowning as he looked at the young lady in front of him. “You came here alone again. How many times have I told you that a cemetery is not a place for a little child like you to come by yourself, especially when it is close to dusk?”

“I already told my mother,” the girl called Annie answered with a grin. “She said it’s fine as long as I go home before curfew.”

The Old Caretaker quietly watched the smiling young lady in front of him.

Most people here did not like the cemetery wardens. They liked it even less when they had to come close to this eerie and dangerous place. But the world always had its exceptions – for example, a young lady who was not afraid of him.

“Grandpa Caretaker, has my dad been brought here yet?” Annie tilted her head back. Snowflakes fell at dusk, and in that falling snow she looked up at the hunched old man in black with full expectation. The cloudy eyes that made most people feel afraid did not make her nervous at all.

“…No,” the Old Caretaker answered as he always did. His voice was as cold and hard as the wind circling in the graveyard. “He will not arrive today.”

Annie did not look disappointed. She smiled as usual. “Then I’ll come and ask again tomorrow.”

“He won’t come tomorrow either.”

Annie still lifted her head. “But he will come one day, right?”

This time, the old man who always sounded so cold finally fell silent for a moment. Only when snow landed on his eyebrows did his cloudy, dark eyes move slightly. “The dead will always gather in cemeteries and, beyond that gate, enjoy peace forever. But it may not be in a cemetery of this world, and it may not be this particular cemetery.”

“Oh.” Annie answered softly, but she did not seem to take the words to heart. She only turned her head, glanced at the locked iron gate, then asked with curiosity: “Can I go inside and take a look? I want to warm myself by the fire in your little house…”

“Not today.” The old man shook his head. “Cemetery No. 3 is in a special state. Church Guardians are stationed inside. It is not open to visitors today. You should go home, young lady.”

“…All right.” Annie nodded, a little disappointed. Then she reached into the small bag she carried and took out a small package wrapped in rough paper. She held it out to the old man. “Then this is for you. My mother baked these cookies. She said I shouldn’t always be causing trouble.”

The old man looked at the thing in her hand, then at the snow on her clothes.

He reached out, took the cookies, then casually patted her wool cap, brushing the snow from it. “I’ll accept them. You should go home early.”

“Okay, Grandpa Caretaker.”

Annie nodded with a smile. She straightened her scarf and gloves, then started toward the little path that led back to the residential districts of the city.

But she had taken only a few steps when the Old Caretaker suddenly turned and called to her: “Annie.”

“Eh?”

“Annie, you are twelve years old now,” the old man said. He stood in the twilight and looked calmly into the girl’s eyes. “Do you still believe the words I told you when you were six?”

The girl stopped and stared at the cemetery warden in a daze.

The dead would all come to this cemetery. No matter how they had wandered and been scattered in life, Bartok’s Hall would be the place of their final gathering.

Those words were written in the scriptures of the Church. But when they faced that same line of teaching, adults and a six-year-old child would always have different understandings.

Twelve-year-old Annie stood there for a long time, staring. The black-clad cemetery warden stood at the tall, locked gate like a cold iron statue. Snowflakes fluttered between them. The chill of winter filled the dusk.

Then suddenly, Annie smiled. She waved at the old man and said: “Then just think I’m here to see you. My mother says older people need someone to talk to now and then.”

The young lady turned and ran off, light as a small bird as she flitted along the path where snow was starting to gather. She slipped once at the end of the slope, but she got up at once, patted the snow and dust from her skirt and warm pants, and hurried away.

“…Older people…” The Old Caretaker watched the girl’s receding figure. Only when she had run far away did he start to mutter. “This child has picked up some bad tricks.”

“Breaking a child’s hope is a bit worse than that,” a young, slightly hoarse woman’s voice suddenly came from the side, cutting off the Old Caretaker’s grumbling. “You didn’t need to say those words just now. A twelve-year-old child is already starting to understand what she should. Sometimes we hard-hearted grown-ups don’t need to tear every truth open in front of them.”

The Old Caretaker turned and saw a black-clad “Gatekeeper”, Agatha, already standing at the cemetery gate without him noticing. Bandages were wrapped under her black clothes, and the gate that had been locked a moment ago was now open.

He shook his head. “Let her keep hoping that her father will be sent to this cemetery, and then let her come alone to this cursed place on a snowy, freezing day?”

“Is that so bad? At least when you talk to that child, you look like you still have some warmth.”

“…That doesn’t sound like something a Gatekeeper should say.”

Agatha shook her head and said nothing. She turned and walked along the inner path of the cemetery.

The Old Caretaker followed. He first turned back to lock the gate again, then went to his warden’s hut to put away the things he had bought. After he finished handing the shift over to the day warden, he went to the mortuary area inside the cemetery and found the Gatekeeper, who had already gone ahead.

Compared to before, the mortuary yard was clearly much more empty. Most of the stone platforms were bare now. Only a few of the platforms near the edge still held plain wooden coffins.

Around those few coffins, at least two Church Guards stood by each platform. In the open areas between the platforms, black Gatekeeper’s canes were stuck into the ground. The black Gatekeeper’s cane was the mark of a guardian of the Death God’s Church. They planted the canes into the earth nearby and hung holy consecrated lanterns from the tops. In this way they kept a small area of Sanctum, which could effectively resist the forces of corruption that came from Higher Beings.

dusk had deepened, and the snowy weather made the sky far darker than on a normal day at this time. In the steadily darkening cemetery, the consecrated lanterns hanging from the tops of the Gatekeeper’s canes burned quietly like ghostly fire, filling the place with a still, eerie atmosphere.

“We have done quite a lot of preparation here, but it seems our ‘visitor’ has no plans to return anytime soon,” Agatha said casually when she saw the Old Caretaker arrive. “Are you sure that ‘visitor’ really mentioned the intention to come again?”

“You should trust the hypnosis skills of a professional psychiatrist,” the Old Caretaker said, shrugging. After a short pause, he added, “I can’t remember most of what happened that day. Those buzzing noises are also slowly fading from my mind. But after several rounds of hypnosis, I can recall a few things… The clearest of them is that the ‘visitor’ did reveal an intention to visit again before leaving.”

Agatha stayed silent for two or three seconds. After thinking, she said softly: “But there is another possibility. A Higher Being’s sense of time is very likely not the same as a mortal’s. When They speak of returning, it might mean tomorrow, or it might mean several years from now. More likely, it might mean after you are dead, when They reach you in some way that goes beyond life and death.”

“…Can’t you hope for something better for me?”

“This is the conclusion of the Holy See’s advisory council.”

The Old Caretaker only gave a vague grunt in reply. His eyes moved over the black-clad guards in the cemetery and the consecrated lanterns burning quietly on top of the Gatekeeper’s canes.

“…I only hope these arrangements don’t anger that ‘visitor’,” he said at last. “I hope They don’t see this as some kind of insult or trap. In the end, we know far too little about Them.”

“All these arrangements are only for our own protection,” Agatha said. “After all, even though you say you fell into a Spirit Sight runaway state just because you breathed in too much incense, none of us knows whether that ‘visitor’ has any tendency to actively release spiritual corruption. If we want to face a high-ranking supernatural, we must at least make sure of our own sanity.”

The Old Caretaker neither agreed nor denied it. After a short moment of thought, he suddenly changed the subject. “Those samples you took away earlier – have you found any conclusions?”

“Do you mean those cultists, or that heap of ‘corpses’ that melted into sludge?”

“Both.”

“As for those cultists, there isn’t much to say. They were claws of the Cult of Annihilation, supernatural individuals who had already formed deep symbiotic pacts with demons. Their strength was impressive. An ordinary Church Guard would be in great danger fighting any one of them. Sadly, those heretics clearly lacked good luck. As for that ‘sludge’…”

Agatha paused here, and her expression turned a little strange.

“Their ‘evolution’ has in fact not stopped even now. By the time I left the Great Cathedral, those things were still showing new forms and properties. In the recent period, they even briefly took on states similar to metal and stone. The feeling they gave… was almost like a certain thing those Annihilators often mention in their heretic teachings.”

The Old Caretaker slowly furrowed his brow. “You mean… ‘elements’?”

“The true essence, the purest and holiest matter, the ‘drops of reality’ that the Abyssal Lord gifted to the mortal world – that’s how those heretics describe it.” Agatha’s voice held open disgust and mockery. “Such beautiful words, put in their mouths, are simply sickening.”

Chapter 322: Another Blind Box, Same Old Place Again

Listening to the open disgust in Agatha's voice when she spoke about the Annihilators, the Old Caretaker showed almost no change in expression. Most of his attention still stayed on the latest report.

The "samples" taken from the graveyard had shown properties in the lab that looked very much like what those cultists described as "elements".

No matter how insane those Heretic cultists were, no matter how twisted and inhuman their doctrines sounded, as a member of the Church of the True Gods, the Old Caretaker still had to study their information. He had to understand their mad teachings and their highly corruptive system of knowledge.

And within the Annihilators' whole set of Heretic dogma, everything always circled around one core:

The Abyssal Lord, and the many "sacred miracles" created by the Abyssal Lord.

The Annihilators believed that the mortal world blessed by the Gods was not a "peaceful paradise" at all. In truth, it was a land that had already been deeply corroded and completely twisted, a "place of exile".

They claimed that the light and prosperity of the Mortal Realm were illusions woven by the Gods, and that the true destination of Mortal souls,

and the “uncorrupted Mortal Realm”, were not here at all, but in the deep layers of the world – the domain of the Abyssal Deep.

On that basis, they believed the Abyssal Lord and the demons around Him showed the purest, most original, and least corrupted form of this world. They claimed that only by purifying their filthy flesh could Mortals “return” to the Abyssal Deep and go back to the original land.

But the mortal world was sealed by the Gods. There was a barrier between the “twisted Mortal Realm” and the “true Mortal Realm” (that is, the Abyssal Deep Sea). The Mortal body of flesh and blood was the physical form of that barrier.

As long as a Mortal’s soul was trapped in this shell and endured a lifetime of constant corruption, it would be impossible to return to the Abyssal Deep.

So, the Abyssal Lord would send down sacred miracles called “elements”.

The Heretics believed this holy substance was the foundation of all things at the birth of the world. The Lord’s Blueprint for shaping the Mortal Realm was hidden at the microscopic level inside elements.

Only elements, they said, could fight the curse in the flesh of all living beings in this world and let Mortals return to their “pure form at the dawn of creation”.

About this substance called “elements”, the Annihilators described it like this:

“…It will show all the properties of everything in this world and remain in an endless cycle of evolution. It represents all the plans and the Blueprint the Abyssal Lord used when shaping the Mortal Realm, and shortsighted Mortals will never be able to measure any exact property of elements…”

The Old Caretaker suddenly raised his head and stared into Agatha's eyes: "Do you think that is 'elements'?"

Agatha answered without a second of doubt: "elements is just nonsense made up by those Heretics. It is very likely just some new substance that our current system of knowledge cannot explain yet. Its changing properties might be some kind of natural phenomenon, or some kind of supernatural power – but it cannot be a 'sacred miracle' sent down by the Abyssal Lord."

But in the face of this answer, the Old Caretaker's expression still did not change. He just quietly used his gaze to watch the Gatekeeper: "Do you think that is 'elements'?"

When he asked a second time, Agatha finally fell silent for a short moment. After two or three seconds, she let out a light breath: "But I have to admit, at least in terms of properties… the samples we brought back match those Heretics' description."

The Old Caretaker raised his head and looked toward the mortuary not far away.

The light snow that had begun after nightfall was slowly growing heavier. Snowflakes were drifting down from the dark night sky. One gatekeeper's cane after another stood in the dim graveyard, and the consecrated lanterns on top of each cane lit the falling snow around them, adding a faint, hazy texture to everything.

His gaze passed through the drifting flakes and the lantern light and fell on an empty slab not far away.

There had once been a special corpse placed there.

"Those samples used to be a person – at least they used to look like a person," the Old Caretaker spoke as if to himself. "You led the team that brought him in. You should remember."

“Of course I remember,” Agatha said softly. “Very few bodies ever need a Gatekeeper to transport them in person. And that body fell into the deepest part of the mine. That is the deepest place in this whole city-state. Any dead brought up from there… are special.”

“But his level of ‘special’ still went beyond everyone’s expectations,” the Old Caretaker said as he turned his head and looked at the young Gatekeeper. “You found the real man who fell into the shaft the very next day, so that corpse was clearly only a ‘replica’ of the real dead… a replica made from elements. No wonder it drew the attention of those Oblivion Heretics.”

“Maybe it didn’t just draw their attention. Maybe the whole thing was their doing from the start,” Agatha shook her head. “We suspect that mine accident was caused by the cultists. Their goal was to use a sacrifice in the depths of the mine to make a ‘replica’, like some kind of sacrificial ritual. But clearly, something went wrong with their plan. That was why the replica was accidentally found, and even carried here to your cemetery.”

The Old Caretaker shrugged: “And it also drew the notice of an indescribable ‘visitor’.”

“…Yes, an indescribable visitor,” a flicker finally passed over Agatha’s always-calm face, and her tone became careful. “To this day we still do not know what He wants.”

The Old Caretaker looked up at the sky. After a moment of silence, he spoke: “It is late.”

The graveyard fell silent for a time. An unspeakable strangeness and quiet hung over the paths and platforms, soaked into the night wind that carried the swirling snow.

Everyone was waiting – waiting for an indescribable visitor, or for a safe and uneventful sunrise.

No one knew how long that silence lasted. Just as Agatha was about to urge the Old Caretaker to go back to his hut and rest, a series of light tapping sounds suddenly broke the night.

A clear, low voice came from one of the nearby coffins:

“Why did you stop talking?”

The sudden voice in the quiet graveyard startled even the well-trained Church guards for a moment. Agatha even felt as if the snowflakes drifting in the lantern light froze in place for two seconds. The next second, all the Guardians quickly moved to surround the coffin that had just spoken. Their boots thudded densely on the snow.

Agatha almost turned into a pale blur in an instant. She moved as if she had teleported to the side of the slab and stared hard at the coffin that had made the sound. Only after taking two deep breaths did she manage to keep her voice as calm as possible: “Are you… the visitor from the other day?”

“Sorry for dropping in. I hope I did not frighten you,” Duncan said from inside the coffin. He thought for a moment, then greeted them in a casual tone. “I did come once two days ago, but some cultists made trouble at the time, so my contact with the warden did not go very smoothly.”

Footsteps came from the side. The Old Caretaker, eyes dark and wary, carefully approached the coffin. He swept the dark wood with the corner of his eye in a quick glance, then pulled his gaze back at once.

Even though he had not fallen into runaway spirit sight this time because of the incense, and even though he had taken a potion beforehand to resist mental corruption, the psychological shadow from their last “contact” was

too heavy. Even as a battle-hardened veteran, he looked very cautious at this moment.

“…Have you been here this whole time?” After calming down a little, the Old Caretaker finally broke the silence.

“Since you started talking about that ‘elements’,” Duncan’s voice came from the coffin. “I felt like I was hearing some very interesting news – but you suddenly stopped.”

Agatha lifted her head and exchanged a shocked look with the Old Caretaker.

Her lips moved slightly, but her voice went straight into the Old Caretaker’s mind: “Is this visitor… always this easygoing?”

The Old Caretaker shrugged and also moved his lips slightly: “How would I know?”

The two Church priests finished their short exchange. Then Agatha waved her hand lightly to the people around them.

The black-clad guards who had gathered around the coffin quietly stepped back a little. They did it to avoid letting their overly cautious reaction look like a challenge in the eyes of the “visitor” who had descended into this corpse.

Duncan, lying in the coffin, had already sensed all the auras around him. He had been lying in there for more than just a few minutes. From the moment the Old Caretaker and the young woman started talking about “elements”, he had been patiently and curiously listening in.

Now, as he felt the people around him move away, he laughed and said: “There are quite a lot of people here tonight.”

“…We have no wish to offend you,” Agatha answered at once, very carefully. For now she still could not tell what kind of being this “visitor” really was. But at least he had not shown any open hostility. When dealing with a high-ranked, non-hostile “godlike” presence, showing enough courtesy was the first step to communication. “All these arrangements are only to protect our own sanity.”

“Oh, I understand. People often start having problems in the head when they are talking to me. To be honest, it can be pretty troublesome,” Duncan said with a light smile in his voice. “It is good that you know how to protect yourselves.”

Agatha frowned slightly.

She had dealt with many supernatural beings before, including cruel and vicious ones, as well as chaotic and dangerous ones. But this was the first time she had met one who chatted with her like this.

“May we know what kind of being you are?” After a moment’s hesitation, she finally gathered her courage and asked.

Duncan lay in the coffin and thought seriously.

He remembered the brilliant record of the Vanished dragging the Viseran Thirteen Isles into Subspace, and he remembered what he had learned from talking with Morris and Vanna about the link between those thirteen islands and the death cult.

“I am just the Nameless Traveler. Do not be curious about my real name – that will be better for both of us.”

Chapter 323: At Death’s Door

After thinking it over, Duncan still decided not to reveal his identity for now. After all, he now knew the details behind the glorious “battle record” of the Vanished back then.

A century ago, “he” had sunk the largest faith center of the death Church in one go, and in the most terrifying way – by dragging it straight into Subspace.

If you put it in modern terms, it was about the same as blowing up Pland right in front of Gamona and scattering its ashes on the spot.

He figured that if he suddenly said the words “Captain Duncan” right now, the people outside the coffin might start shouting slogans and rushing in to die for their faith on the spot. By then, it would not matter what he tried to say.

He had seen how fierce loyal Believers could be. Back then, Vanna had no deep hatred for him at all, yet she had still greeted him with a flying cleave the moment they met. And the death God Believers here had held a blood feud with the Vanished for a full century…

But this awkward dodge from Duncan sounded very different in the ears of Agatha and the Old Caretaker.

The young Gatekeeper and the aging cemetery warden instinctively exchanged a look.

“This is a kind of protection,” Agatha said in a low voice. “The name of a high-ranked supernatural being carries power.”

The Old Caretaker nodded slightly: “A friendly existence. At least for now.”

Agatha steadied herself and set these thoughts aside. Her gaze returned to the coffin, but a new doubt rose in her mind: why did this visitor always choose the dead as a “medium” to make contact with the Mortal Realm?

Did that mean… he was a being who held power in the domain of death?

Yet as a high-ranking priest of the God of Death, she had never heard of such a being in the field of death. A single avatar form that could make a battle-hardened cemetery warden like the Old Caretaker fall into temporary madness the first time they met – an supernatural of that level could not possibly leave no trace at all in the records.

Even with all these questions in her heart, Agatha did not show it. She used a calm and proper voice to ask: “May I ask what your purpose is in coming here?”

“I was passing through, and then I noticed this city-state is wrapped in shadows,” Duncan casually repeated the cover story he had prepared long ago. “Those shadows bother me.”

“Shadows?” Agatha frowned. She quickly thought of the disturbance that had taken place in this cemetery earlier and reacted at once. “Do you mean those Annihilators? Their activities…”

“They are not worthy of being called shadows. The true shadows stand behind them,” Duncan said slowly. He knew the young woman’s voice outside represented the Church’s influence in the upper levels of Frostholm. Guiding her mind was really the same as warning the authorities of Frostholm. He had already prepared a whole package of things to report.

“Have you really noticed nothing? The Abyssal Lord’s power is spreading beneath your city…”

“What did you say?” For the first time, Agatha’s calm expression showed a hint of a runaway state. All the plans she had formed in her head up to now had not included anything like this. “The Abyssal Lord?! His power is spreading under the city… what does that mean?”

Jumping straight from Annihilators to the Abyssal Lord behind them… that was a completely different level of trouble!

“Here is a suggestion. Why not widen the scope of your investigation?” Duncan did not directly answer her question. He just continued: “The Annihilators active in the city are only small ripples before a great wave. Something much larger is lurking under the surface.

“Take a close look at the Deep Sea, look at an old Deep Dive plan that almost everyone has forgotten, and look at the things that have recently risen from the Deep Sea. All of these are connected.”

Agatha and the Old Caretaker stared at each other.

The young Gatekeeper could not connect too many points at once. But the Old Caretaker, who had lived through a certain era himself, instantly thought of something.

“Do you mean… the Abyssal Trench Project?” the old man blurted out. When he said the words “Abyssal Trench Project”, his voice clearly paused for a moment. “Why would you know that…”

He broke off halfway.

It was not so surprising for a very high-ranked Higher Being to know about some secrets among Mortals.

Agatha’s eyes widened slightly. Her gaze moved quickly back and forth between the Old Caretaker and the coffin. Then she stopped and quickly whispered to the old man beside her: “I have to warn City Hall… something might happen near Dagger Island.”

“You had better go now,” the Old Caretaker answered just as quickly under his breath.

While the two of them talked quietly, Duncan’s voice suddenly came again from the dark coffin: “Then my warning has been delivered. I will not stay any longer.”

Agatha froze, then spoke without thinking: “You are leaving already?”

“I still have some things to do,” the voice in the coffin said. It sounded a little rushed. “If I get the chance, I will come visit again.”

When he finished speaking, the coffin went completely quiet.

The visitor had left, and he had left quite suddenly. Agatha and the Old Caretaker were a bit stunned. They had not expected that the mysterious “Visitor” would come this night only to say a few sentences, only to deliver a warning.

Such a sudden arrival and sudden departure made him seem even harder to grasp in their eyes.

While the two in the graveyard were still in shock, Duncan had already returned to that dim, chaotic, strange space.

He really had left in a hurry. In his first plan, he had meant to stay in the cemetery a bit longer. He had even thought about climbing out of the coffin to have a formal meeting with the cemetery warden and the Gatekeeper named “Agatha”.

But just now, while he was walking in the Spirit Realm, he had suddenly sensed something odd.

In the endless dark, star-filled space, Duncan looked up. His gaze fell not far away.

The countless tiny stars that represented the living beings of Frostholm were twinkling in the void. Among them, one star’s flickering was showing a strange change and releasing a strange aura.

Duncan moved closer and used his gaze on that “star”.

Its light was fading quickly, as if a living life was rapidly slipping away. But at the edge of that dim light, something else was quietly drawing near, trying to tangle with that star.

After a moment of thought, Duncan reached out toward that light.

…

On the cold sea completely covered by the veil of night, a few pieces of wreckage that had not been swallowed by the vortex were bobbing up and down in the waves, drifting north toward Frostholm under the push of the currents.

One larger piece of wreckage had broken away from the other fragments like a lone canoe. On this piece of wreckage, a huge, almost unrecognizable body suddenly twitched twice.

The body wore a torn military uniform. Horrible burn marks covered it everywhere. The flames had left shocking scars all over. The hair on the head had been burned away, and the face was so ruined it was hard to tell what it had looked like before.

The left arm was twisted in a strange angle, clearly broken by some enormous impact. Both legs were bent out of shape, skin split open and

flesh torn.

Yet almost no blood flowed from those wounds – the heat of the explosion had already cauterized them all.

The injuries were terrifying, but this body… was still alive.

Belazov tried to open his eyes. He tried several times and felt as if he tore some part of his burned eyelids before he finally managed to see a faint, blurry patch of light and shadow.

Slow, muddled pain spread through every part of his body. It felt as if a rusty saw had shredded all the organs in his chest into tiny pieces. But all these sensations blended together in a strange numbness, so that he could no longer tell which feeling came from which part of his body – he could not even be sure if his limbs were still connected to his torso.

He knew his nervous system had probably collapsed. All his organs were failing fast. The last bit of adrenaline in his body was working as hard as it could to keep his brain going. He had not really survived the blast – he had only not died yet.

Fragments of memory slowly rose up in his mind. He still remembered what had happened on Dagger Island. He also remembered noticing something odd on the ship and activating “Protocol Twenty-Two”.

He felt a little surprised. In an explosion like that, he had not died on the spot. Somehow, he still had one last breath left. He could even look back on his life as he lay dying.

Maybe it was because the captain’s cabin was especially strong and blocked some of the blast. Or maybe it was because he had failed to save the thirty-one normal crew members who might have been on that ship, so he had to suffer all this pain now, as punishment for his failure.

But none of that mattered anymore.

He could just barely see the wreckage floating on the nearby sea. From this, he could tell that the Sea Swallow had been completely destroyed. The main structure of the ship should already have sunk into the depths.

He no longer had the strength to worry about whether those sunken remains would bring some new, unpredictable disaster. He had done his duty. He had done all he could to keep his oath of loyalty. Everything else was already beyond him.

Belazov slowly let out a breath. In the tearing pain in his chest, he calmly waited for the door of God of Death Bartok to open before him.

But the first one to meet him was not death’s Envoy.

Under the cold glow of the World’s Wound, a tall young man in a blue coat, holding a gatekeeper’s cane, had somehow appeared at the edge of the drifting wreck.

A length of black chain stretched out from the back of the young man’s skull, drifting upward into the air through a cloud of smoke. At the end of the chain floated a strange creature made of what looked like smoke and dust, its outline like that of a jellyfish.

Chapter 324: Critical Intelligence

In the last clear moment of his life, Belazov saw the figure standing at the edge of the wreckage.

The man’s tall, thin, and slightly pale face was reflected in Belazov’s pupils. At the same time, he also saw the black chains floating in midair, and at the end of those chains, the Abyssal demon—“Smokewisp Jellyfish”.

After a brief moment of shock, Belazov finally remembered one scene after another. He remembered this figure. He remembered those moments that had always been blocked from his conscious mind. He remembered that when he set foot on Dagger Island, this tall, thin heretic had been standing on the shore. When he entered the “secret room”, the heretic had walked at his side. When he returned to the Sea Swallow, the heretic had been standing inside the cabin…

Belazov’s eyes went wide. The charred skin on his face seemed to crackle as it split. He wanted to shout, wanted to speak, but only a low hissing came from his chest. At the same time, the tall, thin figure with the pale face finally lowered his head and looked down at the dying General.

“I admit I was careless,” the tall, pale man said calmly. His voice almost held no emotion at all. It was as if he was not speaking to a person, but muttering to a piece of rotten wood. “When you were walking around the ship, I only thought you were checking on the posts and positions—General Belazov, I must admit, your acting was excellent.”

Belazov only stared at him, eyes locked on the man. Fury boiled in his chest, but he could no longer drive this once-strong body to move.

“What a pity. You were just about to become an Envoy,” the tall man said with a hint of regret, shaking his head. “You would have brought the Lord’s radiance into the city-states, freed the mortals tormented by filth, and allowed the first paradise to descend upon this dirty, twisted Mortal Realm. Such a glorious chance, and you threw it away… you were only a step away.”

“Her… etic…” Belazov finally squeezed a trace of sound out of his chest. His teeth and bones scraped with a harsh creak. “You… will never lay your hands on…”

“Save your strength, General,” the tall man said, stepping forward. He looked down at the body lying in the center of the wreckage, already half among the dead. “Calmly accept your death. The Lord’s divine blessing will let this pitiful shell of yours be born again—you’ve wasted your chance to become an Envoy, but the merciful Lord still won’t abandon your suffering soul…”

With that bewitching whisper, the tall man slowly reached out his right hand. The Smokewisp Jellyfish floating behind him rose and writhed in response. From its gauzy, mist-like body, a growing red glow began to seep out. The blood-red light reflected in Belazov’s darkening pupils as his body grew colder and colder. His consciousness seemed to fade away completely, no longer reacting to the outside world at all.

“That took more work than it should have,” the tall man said, shaking his head. At last there was a trace of feeling in his voice. “Damn it. If it weren’t for that Queen… tsk.”

A sticky, eerie sound of writhing and sliding began to echo. The seawater surging around the wreckage started to bubble with abnormal black foam.

In the foam, strange, mud-like material slowly rose up and spread bit by bit toward Belazov’s corpse.

But just one second before that mud-like substance touched the body, it suddenly stopped.

Even the seawater around them seemed to freeze in place.

The tall man stared in shock. He instinctively tried again to connect with the Smokewisp Jellyfish, hoping to use the power of a Abyssal Deep spell to complete the next step of the ritual. But in the next second, he saw the General’s lifeless body suddenly move.

“Your vitality really is stubborn,” the tall man said, frowning despite himself. “Wouldn’t it be better to calmly accept your fate, General Duncan?”

“No.”

The big body lying at the center of the wreckage, almost burned to charcoal, opened its eyes again. Duncan looked at the cultist, his gaze carrying a calm gaze, a gaze that saw straight through the Abyssal demon bound to him by a symbiotic pact. “Continue. ‘If it weren’t for that Queen’—what comes after that?”

The tall man blinked.

Something was wrong.

He did not know what had happened, but in that instant all his instincts suddenly screamed. A terrible sense of danger seemed to pour out of his soul and flood his mind. He stared at the body whose eyes had opened once more. His instincts told him to step back, but his legs refused to obey.

Then the tall man finally noticed the strange changes in Duncan’s body. Duncan’s breathing was steady and strong. His voice was low and calm. His

eyes were full of life. The man who had been dying just a moment before now seemed to have regained all his vitality.

The General even sat up.

"'If it weren't for that Queen'—what comes after that?" Duncan rose slowly to his feet. In this tall, burly body, he could even look down at the cultist. He stared into the cultist's eyes and spoke with steady seriousness: "The Queen you mentioned… you mean the Frostholm Queen, Ray Nora?"

As he spoke, Duncan's gaze slid past the cultist's shoulder and fell on the Smokewisp Jellyfish floating in the air behind him.

The jellyfish had already begun to react.

Abyssal demons could sense things that mortals could not. Even without eyes, nose, or mouth, that cloud of smoke clearly "saw" the truth inside the burned shell before it. It trembled, and the trembling grew more and more violent. Threads of black shadows leaked from its edges, prying at the passage between the Abyssal Deep's Deep Sea and the Mortal Realm.

Duncan could not help feeling a bit helpless. If not for this Abyssal demon, it would have been easier to keep pretending to be a dying General and squeeze more information out of the cultist.

"Who are you?!" The cultist finally reacted. The intense wrongness he felt and the constant danger signals from his symbiotic demon were enough to show how serious the situation was. Even if he could not understand what had happened, he knew that the soul inside this shell was no longer the original one. "If you are only passing through, I have no wish to clash with you…"

"Getting polite all of a sudden?" Duncan raised an eyebrow. This cultist was sharper than the two he had met in the graveyard. "Then why don't you

tell me what you and your fellow believers are planning to do? And how that connects to the ‘Queen of Frostholm’?”

As he spoke, he suddenly lifted his head and looked at the Smokewisp Jellyfish floating in the air: “Don’t run.”

The Smokewisp Jellyfish suddenly shook hard. The black cracks spreading out around it shattered at once, breaking apart with a harsh tearing sound.

Abyssal demons were chaotic and dull, but driven by instinct, they still seemed able to “understand” a warning.

Only now did the tall man realize that his symbiotic demon had just tried to open a passage to the Abyssal Deep. A wave of late-coming terror clutched his mind. But he no longer had the time to communicate with his demon—because the “outsider” occupying the General’s body was looking at him with a calm, icy gaze.

“I… am just a nobody,” he said, lifting his head to meet Duncan’s eyes. He seemed to force a smile onto his face. “I don’t know the entire plan. You…”

“Then who does know the entire plan?” Duncan asked, expressionless. “Where are they hiding?”

“My fellow believers… they…” The tall man spread his hands, his expression twisting into something between a smile and a smirk. “They will be glorified because of me—”

Duncan’s brow twitched. Before he could react, a violent surge of energy erupted from inside the cultist’s body. In the next second, the cultist’s body swelled as if filled with air and exploded into a ball of fire.

Duncan only had time to raise his hand. The ghostly green flame formed the Veil, blocking and transforming the flames and shock wave that rushed toward him. When the explosion faded and the surface of the sea grew calm again, the cultist had already turned to ash.

Only a ball of black smoke drifting in the air remained—that was the Smokewisp Jellyfish, which quickly fell apart and vanished after losing the medium of its symbiotic pact.

Duncan stared, stunned, for a long moment before he came back to his senses. He could only look at the bits of debris floating near the wreckage and let out a sigh: “These crazy people really are ruthless… If they weren’t so brainless, they wouldn’t have ended up believing in a cult.”

As he spoke, he shook his head.

The cultist had already blown himself to pieces. No amount of regret would change that. Still, even though he had not gotten more clues from the man’s own mouth, Duncan had already gained plenty of useful information by “possessing” Belazov.

And among all that information, the most useful thing was without a doubt the cultist’s final mention of the “Queen”.

From the sound of it, the Frostholm queen who had died in a rebellion half a century ago… had caused great trouble for some operation of the cultists. That trouble had lasted all the way to the present. Even now, they still had to spend much more effort whenever they acted.

Duncan raised a hand and rubbed his chin, then lifted his gaze in thought.

Night had grown deep. The pale light of the World’s Wound shone faintly over the distant sea. At the end of the water, he could see the lights of the city-state’s coastline.

He did not know where Dagger Island lay, but it was clearly not far from Frostholm’s main island.

He might as well use this body to go to Frostholm—its appearance was a bit tragic, but at least it would not fall apart halfway like the last body.

Duncan let out a breath and walked toward the edge of the wreckage. At the same time, he called for AI in his mind, ready to have it carry him to the nearby shore.

But in the next second, he suddenly stopped.

He lowered his head in surprise.

This body… refused to follow his order.

Chapter 325: Handover

A weak yet strange power was resisting Duncan’s command over the body.

It was even trying to drive him out of it.

This power seemed to have been there from the very beginning, but it only became stronger and clearer after Duncan had the thought of going to Frostholm.

Duncan stopped in surprise. Even though that resisting force was still there, he still managed to shuffle step by step to the edge of the wreckage and look down at the now-calm sea.

He spoke softly: “I thought you had already faded away. Normally, after the heart stops beating, the soul leaves quickly.”

Then he fell quiet, feeling that faint but stubborn power. After a short silence, the body’s lips moved twice: “Leave…”

Duncan slowly closed his eyes.

On the oil-streaked sea, the body’s reflection was suddenly wrapped in a layer of ghostly green flame. In the flame, the ruined face flickered, then shifted into Duncan Abnomar’s stern, deep features.

“Hello,” Duncan said in the reflection on the sea, his gaze fixed on the body standing at the edge of the Sea Swallow’s wreckage. His voice was calm. “I think this way it will be easier for us to talk.”

The ruined body stood rigid and straight. The last trace of Belazov’s mind stared at the face in the water and at the ghostly green fire around it. His

lips trembled again and pressed out the same stubborn word: "…Leave."

In the water, Duncan seemed thoughtful. "You're not asking me to leave your body. You are telling me to stay away from Frostholm?"

Belazov's body stayed silent. The body that should already have been fully dead still stood there, firm and unmoving, refusing Duncan's command to return to Frostholm.

"…You're the first to resist me—at least, the first to resist strongly enough that I can feel it," Duncan said calmly. "But you should know this weak resistance is meaningless. You're only burning out your soul faster. At most, you'll slow me down by a few seconds."

Belazov's body remained motionless, as if truly dead. But in those half-open eyes, a tiny spark of light still lingered.

"…I take that back. Your resistance does have meaning," Duncan said at last with a sigh. "Go in peace. I am not an enemy of Frostholm. I came here to help your city and your people."

He then fell silent for a few seconds. Looking at the still figure, he thought for a moment, then spoke softly: "Reinforcements have arrived."

Belazov's body swayed slightly, twice. Perhaps Duncan's words really reached him, or perhaps the last stubborn bit of his soul finally faded. The burly body lifted its head one last time toward the distant city lights. Then it fell straight backward with a crash.

Duncan sat up and roughly straightened the burned scraps of cloth on his body. Then he looked down at his hands.

That faint resisting force had vanished.

A whirl of spreading firelight suddenly appeared beside him. The sound of beating wings came from the vortex-like gate of flame. The huge skeletal

bird rushed out of the spinning fire and circled over the nearby sea.

Almost at the same time, Goathead's voice sounded in Duncan's mind: "You didn't need to 'negotiate' with him. That was only a weak mortal soul."

"Weak, but worth respecting," Duncan said as he reached out his hand. AI flew to his side at once. The blazing ghostly green flame at Duncan's side rose and twisted, forming a doorway. "I'm heading to Frostholm, and I'll focus most of my attention there. You'll command the Vanished. And tell Alice to prepare some bandages and a large coat. Have her wait for my orders."

The spirit form flames roared outward. Duncan's body merged with the fire and, in the next second, turned into a column of burning light beside AI. Then a meteor-like streak of fire rose from the sea and shot straight toward Frostholm in the night sky.

…

At the same time, in the warm southern seas, lay the technical city-state of Lightwind Harbor, ruled by elves.

It was still deep in the night. Most of the city was covered under the endless veil of night. But on the eastern edge of Lightwind Harbor, a hazy and gentle glow still shone on the buildings and streets. Elegant, sharp-topped towers and houses with tall, steep roofs, full of elven style, were bathed in that glow. Vines hanging between the houses and the trees growing in the narrow spaces between lots looked lush and green.

This dreamlike scene in the Mortal Realm could make one think of the landscapes described in the elves' ancient books—those old scenes woven from forest dreams and strange tales.

Of course, such a sight was not a natural part of the city's scenery. The warm glow covering the eastern districts came from the sea near Lightwind Harbor.

A mountain-sized geometric structure, shining with endless golden light, was floating quietly on the sea near the elven city-state. Even though its outer boundary was still more than ten nautical miles from the city, the strange radiance it released was enough to change the light over almost half the city.

At the edge of this giant geometric body stood the temporary research facilities built by the city-state's authority. Enormous floating-barge harbors drifted on the calm sea. Steam and smoke spurted up from the engines along the edges of the floating platforms. Complex mechanical work towers were busy loading and unloading cargo from the ships moored inside the harbor. Small fast boats were constantly running back and forth between the floating base and the glowing geometric structure, never resting.

Those small boats went deep into the interior of the luminous geometric body. They carried supplies and personnel to the research ship near the "core stone sphere", or brought back important data.

All of these complex, busy, and efficient processes were calculated and coordinated by the giant steam-powered Sorting Engine in the center of the floating base.

At this moment, a "magic warship" very different in style from the local vessels was moored beside the elven-built floating base.

It was the sea witch Lucretia's ship, the Radiant Star.

Clockwork doll Lunie walked lightly up to the upper deck of the Radiant Star. Her mistress was standing on the deck, looking toward the tall and delicate central tower of the sea base.

“Mistress,” Lunie said as she stopped behind Lucretia and bent in a small bow, “the research team led by scholar Taran Ael has already returned from near the core stone sphere. They are now resting in the base. When do you plan to meet him?”

“In the afternoon,” Lucretia said without turning her head. “Let that elven scholar rest a bit more. Ever since we dragged this luminous core to Lightwind Harbor, I haven’t really seen him rest. I’m actually worried he’ll drop dead on my ship.”

Lunie thought for a second. “We could meet him in the sea base instead. We don’t have to let him come on board.”

“…Lunie.”

“Here.”

“Your sense of humor has improved.”

“Thank you for your praise.”

The corner of Lucretia’s mouth twitched. She glanced again at the tall tower in the center of the base. Jets of mist were spraying from the relief pipes on both sides of the tower’s top. That meant the power system of the Sorting Engine was automatically balancing its load. It seemed Master Taran Ael had indeed brought back a large amount of useful data this time.

“Elves really do have outstanding talent in mathematics and machinery. Dragging that thing to Lightwind Harbor was the right choice,” Lucretia said softly. “Only here can we gather a research team of this size at any time, and only here can we provide facilities at this level.”

“Morka could also do it,” Lunie said. “After all, that’s the headquarters of the Academy of Truth. The number of scholars there and their research conditions are even better than here.”

“It’s too far, and too close to the Central Seas—and I don’t plan to let the Radiant Star drag a giant ‘Visitor from Beyond the Sky’ along the main shipping lanes,” Lucretia said, shaking her head. “It would spook those inland city-states that haven’t seen any real storms. And besides, the Four Gods Church is still guessing that this thing is a fragment that fell from Visions 001. An object on that level… is best studied on the edge of civilization.”

Lunie thought it over, then bent a little lower. “Your judgment is most careful.”

Lucretia showed no reaction to the doll maid’s flattery. She only stood there, quietly thinking about something else. Suddenly, she seemed to sense something, and her expression changed slightly.

“I need to step away for a bit. My dear brother is looking for me.”

As soon as she said this, the sea witch turned into a swirl of colorful paper scraps, whirling over the deck like a small storm. She spun through an open window in the distance and flew back into the captain’s cabin.

On the table in the center of the cabin, a lens-and-scrying-crystal device with a complex frame was already glowing faintly and giving off a soft vibration.

Lucretia’s body reformed from the colorful scraps of paper. She walked up to the crystal device and raised her hand to activate the image inside the crystal sphere.

The face of “Steel Vice Admiral” Tyrian appeared in the scrying crystal. The background behind him did not look like any of the rooms she was used to seeing.

“Brother?” Lucretia frowned. At first, she did not pay much attention to his surroundings. “Why did you suddenly call me?”

Tyrian smiled in a mysterious way. “Guess where I am?”

Chapter 326: Close Siblings

Lucretia did not know for a moment how to respond to her elder brother. In the middle of the night, instead of sleeping, he suddenly contacted her across thousands of miles with an Arcane Scrying Orb, just to make this kind of joke.

But very soon, this “Sea Witch” faintly sensed that something was wrong.

Her straight-laced elder brother would never do something like this under normal circumstances. Unlike her, who always moved around alone, her brother had an entire fleet to manage. Also, the room behind him was clearly not on the Sea Mist, yet it looked a bit… familiar?

Through the scrying crystal, Tyrian noticed the change in Lucretia’s expression.

He had specially gone back to the home port to bring the scrying crystal onto the Vanished for this very moment.

“You definitely won’t believe this.” The pirate captain let out a breath and stepped two paces to the side with a smile, letting the scene of the cabin fall right in front of the scrying crystal and the lenses. “I am in my own room—my ‘own room’.”

Lucretia heard the deliberate emphasis in his words and looked at the image in the scrying crystal. At first she seemed confused, then thoughtful. Finally, shock and tension filled her eyes. She lost the calm she had at the beginning and suddenly stood up: “You…”

“As you can see.” Tyrian came back in front of the scrying crystal and spread his hands with a wry smile. “A lot of unexpected things happened in between. The final result is… I came here.”

Lucretia stared blankly at the scrying crystal for a full six or seven seconds. Then she frowned a little and slowly sat back down in her chair.

“I will help you take good care of the Sea Mist Fleet,” she said calmly. “And your twenty-seven bank accounts in Cold Harbor, Morka, Mormenzo, and Zarbustro, as well as the sixty-two treasure caches in the northern seas.”

This time it was Tyrian who jumped up in front of the scrying crystal.

“How do you know…” The pirate lord stared at his younger sister in the scrying crystal in near horror, but the next second he reacted. “You left a mark on the Sea Mist?”

“I do not need such a stupid method,” Lucretia said calmly. “Your way of hiding things was never very clever. From childhood until now, did any of the snacks you hid ever last until the end?”

Tyrian’s expression stiffened for a moment. Then he sighed helplessly: “I thought those hiding places for the treasure were all pretty secret. After all, nothing has ever happened to them for so long…”

“Anyone who owns a fleet as large as the Sea Mist Fleet—no matter if he puts his treasure in the city center, that is still ‘a pirate hoard no one can touch’.”

“I can’t outtalk you.” Tyrian waved a hand, skipping over this slightly awkward topic. “It seems you are not very worried about my safety.”

“I was worried at first, but if you really were in trouble, you would not be in the mood to joke with me,” Lucretia said, still looking indifferent. “So, what exactly happened? Why are you on the Vanished? Father, he…”

“He found my secret Harbor. Maybe you were right—I was never good at hiding things.” Tyrian sighed again. “There have been some problems around Frostholm. Something under the Deep Sea is stirring and drew Father’s attention. Now he has come here in person to investigate and approached me directly.”

Lucretia frowned: “So you have already seen him. I mean face to face.”

Tyrian spread his hands: “Do you even need to ask? I am already on the ship.”

Lucretia fell silent. She seemed to be hesitating about something. After a long time, she finally asked out of nowhere: “…How is Father now?”

“He is now… better than we ever imagined.” Tyrian carefully chose his words, trying not to let his answer be too affected by the absurd things he had experienced on the Vanished. “He really regained his humanity—and he has become even gentler than the man we remember. He talked a lot with me. About the Sea Mist Fleet, about the Frost Sea, about you and me. He also told me some things… related to Subspace. Of course, only in broad strokes.”

“You even talked with him about Subspace?!” Lucretia’s mouth clearly twitched. “Are you sure you are still normal?”

“I was not the one who brought it up on purpose.” Tyrian shrugged. “I just asked a casual question. I asked why the lower deck was locked. Then he told me that the entire lower structure of the Vanished is soaking in Subspace. The main reason the door is locked is to stop people from accidentally falling in.”

Lucretia drew in a quiet breath. Even Tyrian could clearly see her pupils trembling.

“Shock, tension, a sense that it is unbelievable, mixed with the thrill of seeing a whole new world, right?” Tyrian said with a bitter smile. “I understand how you feel. I already went through it once.”

Lucretia did not speak again. She seemed to fall into deep thought.

For less than a second, she even seriously wondered whether her elder brother had already been tainted by Subspace corruption, and whether the person now sitting in front of the scrying crystal was already a madman.

No one knew how long passed before she finally broke the silence again: “What is Father… doing now?”

“I don’t know. He went back to the captain’s cabin. The others on the ship said he is going to use some special methods to investigate the city-state of Frostholm. I did not ask about the details.”

“There are other people on the ship?” Lucretia asked in surprise.

Tyrian opened his mouth. He seemed about to answer, but a sudden knock on the door cut him off. Then he got up and left the front of the scrying crystal. From the sounds coming from off-screen, Lucretia only heard a few vague voices.

It seemed someone had come to deliver something to the room.

A moment later, Tyrian came back into view. There was now a plate in front of him, holding a freshly baked apple pie.

Lucretia’s startled cry came from the scrying crystal at once: “You even have apple pie over there?!”

“The ship now also has hot water and fresh supplies from Pland,” Tyrian said casually. “I know it is hard to picture. In fact, Father even mentioned that he plans to install a steam core on the ship. Then the hot water supply can be twenty-four hours, and we can add a Generator Array…”

As he spoke, he spread his hands again: “The good news is that, from the look of it, Father will no longer mind my modifications to the Sea Mist.”

Lucretia: “…?”

…

The bitter night wind swept along the coast. A faint streak of green flame flashed across the sky and fell in an instant into a deserted corner near the Harbor before anyone could notice it.

Out of the fire stepped a tall, broad figure. His entire body had been burned beyond recognition, a terrifying sight.

Feeling the cold night wind against him, Duncan drew in a deep breath on the soil of Frostholm.

Strictly speaking, this body’s physical structure no longer had the ability to breathe. But he could still feel the air flow into his chest, then leave again, steady and powerful.

“Frostholm…” Duncan lifted his gaze and looked at the part of the city lit up in the distance. Then he shook his head, walked slowly to the shore, and found a still pool of water. By the light spilled from the World’s Wound, he looked at the face now reflected there.

“With this appearance, the constables and guardians really would pin me to the ground the instant I show up.”

The water reflected a hulking, frightening figure. He was full of grim authority, yet also the sort of sight that would send someone running to call the police at first glance.

It was hard to imagine that the original master of this body had still held on to his last bit of clarity by sheer will in his final seconds.

“Belazov, hm… may your soul rest in peace.” Duncan looked at the reflection in the pool and said a last farewell to the former owner of this body. Then he raised his head and looked not far away.

AI was standing on a nearby chunk of broken stone. It spread its wings and let out a loud coo.

Duncan waved his hand, and the dove instantly turned into a stream of flame and vanished into the night sky in the blink of an eye.

Through the link built deep in his mind, he could tell that it had instantly returned to the Vanished.

Just as in the earlier tests—once a round-trip beacon had been set up, AI could use a kind of “teleportation” to cross vast distances in a blink and appear right at any beacon.

Duncan lowered his head and looked at the body he was now using.

The “avatar form” he used when walking through the Spirit Realm was exactly the kind of round-trip beacon that AI could use as a fixed point.

As he confirmed this, he also remembered the temporary body he had taken on his first night in Frostholm.

That body had been extremely weak and able to sense Anomalies. Soon after leaving the coffin, it began to fall apart on its own. At the time, he had no chance to run more tests. But thinking back now, that body had indeed never given him any feedback about “setting up a beacon.”

“One of the traits of a replica, maybe…” Duncan muttered thoughtfully. “Because it is not a complete Mortal body, it cannot carry power?”

While he was still thinking, a crackling burst of flame suddenly cut off his train of thought. Right after that, a door of ghostly green flame appeared out of thin air on the shore beside him.

AI had returned from the Vanished.

Duncan turned to look at the fiery door floating in the air. Three figures were slowly appearing within the glow of the flames.

These were the “helpers” he had asked AI to bring from the Vanished.

Chapter 327: Going Ashore in Disguise

Stepping out of the flaming doorway were Alice in full disguise, Vanna in ordinary clothes, and Morris in a dark gray coat, holding the Gatekeeper's cane.

Duncan needed Morris's learning to help him understand this city and to search for the whereabouts of that "Brown Scott." He needed Vanna's professional skills to track down cultists and, if possible, to establish contact with the local church. As for Alice…

He actually did not need her very much. But Alice wanted to come and take a look. On the other hand, since Alice was wearing the face of Frostholm's Queen, Duncan felt that bringing her along might be a bit of fun.

The ghostly spirit form flames faded quickly into the air. AI turned back into a white dove and landed on a branch nearby. In the cold wind of Frostholm, Morris pulled his thick coat tighter and looked up toward the brightly lit districts. Alice looked around curiously, while Vanna had already noticed the hulking figure standing in the dark.

It was a body that looked terrifying at first glance. That posture of returning from the flames was in no way something a living person should still manage. But this body stood there in the shadows with steady calm, watching them with a peaceful gaze, and the tatters of clothing clinging to it showed what identity this body used to have.

A vague, hard-to-describe “connection” rose in her heart. Vanna fell into a brief daze, then was already sure that this stranger she was seeing for the first time was the captain.

“Mr. Duncan,” she said as she walked up to him, unable to stop herself from giving him another quick once-over. She knew that the captain only used borrowed avatar forms when moving through a city-state. But when she saw the condition of this avatar form, she still could not help frowning a little. “This body of yours…”

“In fact, it is in pretty good shape—only the outside might be a little scary,” Duncan said in a low voice. “Finding an avatar form that is both sound and ‘compatible enough’ is all luck. This body is still better than that ‘sacrificial victim’ you saw in the sewer.”

Vanna instantly remembered some things she did not want to recall. The corner of her eye seemed to twitch, and her voice dropped: “…I would rather not think about that.”

Duncan smiled and lifted his head to look at Alice, who was still peering around everywhere. He waved to her: “Stop staring and come help. Did you bring everything?”

Alice finally came back to herself. She hurried over to Duncan in a few quick steps and lifted the small suitcase in her hand: “I brought it, I brought it! Clothes and bandages… wow! Captain, your face is really dark…”

Duncan ignored the doll’s loud exclamation. He casually took the suitcase from her, opened it, and checked the things inside: a long black coat suitable for hiding the details of his body, with a wide high collar that could cover his face and neck once it was turned up; a matching black wide-brimmed hat; gloves; shoes; some bandages; a bit of cash; and a neatly folded city-state map.

Duncan raised his eyebrows. The things were even more thorough than he had expected.

To get used to this new body, he had been focusing most of his attention on this side and had not paid much attention to what was happening on the ship. When he had Goathead pass a message to Alice, he only said to prepare clothes and bandages. As for the other things, including the cash… that did not seem like something Alice's head would come up with on its own.

"Mr. Tyrian helped prepare them," Alice explained on her own before Duncan could ask. "He heard that you were going to move around in the city-state, so he had me bring these things along too. Oh, right, he also told me to tell you that the map is the newest one. The red marks are the Sea Mist Fleet's secret contact points. There are some lines… some line-thingies…"

"Informants—human members on the Sea Mist Fleet's outer ring," Duncan said casually, with a hint of emotion in his tone. "He said he would never set foot on Frostholm's land again… but his eyes clearly never left this city. He is only one step away from walking in himself."

"Oh, right, informants," Alice said, nodding quickly. Then she leaned over the suitcase again and asked: "Will these things be useful?"

Duncan nodded slightly: "All of them. Tyrian really put some thought into this."

As he spoke, he picked up the bandages and handed them to Vanna beside him: "Give me a hand—you know how to do this, right?"

When Vanna saw what lay in the suitcase, she already knew what Duncan meant to do. She took the bandages, but before wrapping them around the

captain, she still asked, not quite reassured: “Will this really work? I feel it is still a bit too eye-catching…”

“We just need to cover things up. I do not plan to settle in Frostholm in this body,” Duncan said, cooperating with Vanna’s movements. “I only need to walk down the street without drawing the constables. If we run into a situation where it is really hard for me to move, I will need you and Morris to handle it.”

“Alright.” Vanna nodded. Her hands were already moving quickly as she began wrapping the bandages around Duncan. Her motions were skilled. It was clear she had done similar things many times.

On the front line against heretics and malevolent spirits, treating wounds was as normal and inevitable as breathing.

Alice watched Vanna working and looked eager to join in: “Can I help?”

Duncan tilted his head a little and glanced at the doll, who was a bit over one meter sixty. Then he looked at Vanna, who was about one meter ninety.

Then he lowered his eyes to his own current body, which must have been over one meter ninety as well.

“Forget it. If you tilt your head back, it will fall off,” he said, turning down the doll. At the same time, he reminded her, not quite at ease: “Remember, this is a city-state—and Frostholm at that. Keep your disguise in order. It is not just your wig and head that must stay on. Do not take off the veil on your face either. Got it? That face of yours here might scare anyone over fifty half to death.”

Alice answered at once: “Got it!”

Duncan nodded slightly, and his gaze shifted back to Vanna.

To move around and act in an unfamiliar Frostholm, she clearly could not keep that eye-catching armor-and-greatsword look. To move more easily in the city, she now wore everyday clothes.

She had on a gray, fitted women's long coat, with black boots and trousers below. Her gray-white hair still hung loosely down her back as usual. She looked as bold and sharp as ever, but without the armor and greatsword, her presence seemed a little softer.

Even so, with her one meter ninety height, any hope of really blending into the crowd was very slim. Her outfit might avoid direct questioning, but it would never be truly low-key.

While he was thinking, the bandages had already reached his face, wrapping layer after layer around his ruined head.

In the end, his entire face was covered, except for his eyes and a small patch of relatively intact skin near his left eye.

Then he put on the long black coat with the tall collar, as well as the shoes, gloves, and wide-brimmed hat.

Luckily, this body was very broad and solid, almost the same size as his true body, so everything fit quite well.

Duncan gave his clothes a final straightening and carefully fastened the coat buttons all the way to the last one.

He could not see how he looked now, but he could easily imagine it.

A long black coat covering his whole body, a wide-brimmed hat and raised collar hiding his face, black leather gloves, and the faint glimpse of layered bandages in the gaps between hat and coat.

He thought for a moment, then turned to the young Inquisitor standing quietly to the side: "Vanna, tell me honestly…"

Vanna sighed: “Constables and guardians with little experience will probably stop you on sight to question you.”

Duncan was silent for a moment: “…What about the ones with a lot of experience?”

“They will call for backup.”

Duncan: “…”

“Alright, it is not actually that bad,” Vanna said, suddenly laughing a little and shaking her head. “That only applies in the core districts with high security levels—places with strong guard forces. In ordinary districts, you probably will not run into trouble. That is my guess based on what I saw in Pland. Frostholm should be similar. The only real concern is probably just your bandages…”

“The bandages might actually be the best part of the disguise.” Before Vanna finished, Morris spoke up beside them. “They might save us a lot of trouble.”

Duncan glanced over at him: “Oh?”

“Frostholm mainly worships the God of Death. Customs and symbols related to death are its special traits. Devout believers even add bandages and similar things to their clothes on purpose. priests also have such elements in their everyday vestments,” Morris said, thinking as he talked. “At most, people may see you as a rather odd Death believer.”

Hearing this, Vanna blinked: “These details… I had no idea. I only know the doctrines and taboos of the other Three Gods Church branches.”

Morris laughed: “It is hard to know the exact customs of each city-state without studying them.”

Duncan looked at the old scholar: “Is this what that ‘old friend’ of yours shared with you?”

Morris went quiet for a moment and let out a soft sigh: “Yes. Brown Scott was an excellent folklore scholar. He spent his life traveling between many city-states in the central and northern regions, especially Frostholm and Cold Harbor. He wrote me many letters describing the strange customs and beliefs of these places.”

Chapter 328: Sailing to Dagger Island

After they finished their disguises and preparations, Duncan turned his gaze toward the bright, bustling city district.

Vanna judged the state of the city from her own experience: “It is curfew now. There will be Guardian patrols on the streets, but in the outlying areas the patrols will be weaker. Even in a developed place like Pland, the Guardians in the Lower City cannot watch every corner. Usually, the security standard in the outer districts is: ‘If an supernatural runaway state occurs, the nearest squad must be able to reach the scene within twenty minutes, and casualties should not spread to the nearby blocks if it can be helped.’”

“The Sea Swallow exploded in the coastal waters near the city. No one on board survived. That kind of thing cannot be hidden. By now the Frostholm authority should already be busy, but they will probably not be able to reach any conclusion for a while,” Morris said from the side. “We should give them a warning.”

“Oh, that is easy. I am good at all kinds of anonymous reports, and they usually make the local offices very nervous,” Duncan said casually. “But besides giving a warning, we also have to run our own investigation. This whole thing is strange. I can smell a mood in it that feels a bit like what we saw back in Pland. Whatever those cultists are doing… it is probably not small.”

As he spoke, he reached out and picked up the map Tyrian had prepared for him.

The map was very detailed, with all kinds of special marks. It was clearly not something sold to the public inside the city-state. Without a doubt, the Informants Tyrian had planted in this city had contributed a lot to this map.

Duncan quickly found two places that deserved attention: Hearth Street on the edge of the inner city, and a cemetery area that lay even closer to the inner-city core.

His gaze fell on the special block marked as the cemetery district. The whole area was numbered from one to nine, split into nine cemeteries. They almost encircled the Cathedral district at the center of the city-state, laid out in a rough ring. It really did not look like the usual planning of an ordinary city-state.

Was this also because of the faith needs of the God of Death Bartok?

“We will go to Hearth Street first and visit your ‘old friend’,” Duncan lifted his head and glanced at Morris. “After the curfew ends, you and Vanna can find somewhere to stay in the city. Alice and I will make a trip to Cemetery No. 3.”

“Cemetery?” Morris blurted out without thinking.

“Do we not want to give the city-state’s authority a small warning? We cannot just walk up to City Hall or the Cathedral and knock on the door to file a report,” Duncan said with a small smile. “We only need a channel that can pass the message along, and in Cemetery No. 3 I happen to know such a channel.”

Vanna spoke without thinking from the side: “Getting the message there is one thing. What matters more is making them take it seriously…”

Duncan turned his head. A confident smile was on his face: “Do not worry. They will take it very seriously.”

Under the cold, silent night sky, a White Dove flew out from the Frostholm coast into the colors of nightfall, beating its wings toward the lights of the distant city.

At the same time, far away on the Vanished in the Frost Sea, the door of the captain’s cabin finally opened.

Duncan’s figure appeared on the deck.

In the clear, chilly night, he moved his arms, legs, and shoulders a bit, feeling the strange sensation of one mind controlling several bodies at once. Only after the sense of delay slowly faded did he let out a light breath.

He had just spent some time getting used to his new body in Frostholm. Compared with his first clumsy attempt at “splitting his attention” back in Pland, he actually adapted more quickly and smoothly this time, even though he had added one more body.

In just a short while, he was already able to handle affairs on the Vanished while still keeping his actions in Frostholm under control.

Steadying his thoughts a little, Duncan asked in his mind: “Where is Tyrian?”

Goathead’s voice sounded at once: “He is near the aft helm deck. Do you need me to call him?”

“No need. I was going there anyway,” Duncan shook his head, then gave a casual order: “Adjust our course to Dagger Island. Full speed.”

“Yes, Captain!”

Creaking sounds rose from the taut ropes and masts, and the crash of waves against the hull broke the quiet of the night as the huge ship shifted its

heading. Tyrian, who was standing at the stern deck and gazing into the distance, was startled by the sudden movement. He looked up in surprise and saw the dark wheel on the high bridge slowly turning. Under the faint glow from the World's Wound above, it looked as if an invisible person was standing there at the helm.

Even though this was not the first time he had seen such a scene since coming back aboard this ship, Tyrian could not help but frown a little.

Many parts of the Vanished were still the same as in his memories, but the ship kept reminding him, through all kinds of small details, that it was now a ghost ship that had been baptized by Subspace.

While he was lost in thought, Tyrian heard steady, powerful footsteps coming from nearby. He turned toward the sound and saw Father's figure appear on the deck under the veil of night.

"Did the sudden movement scare you?" Duncan had noticed how Tyrian had been staring at the wheel. He spoke with a faint, amused look. "Goathead is steering."

"I know. I have already seen it twice," Tyrian came back to himself and his face returned to normal. "I am just still not quite used to it. The Sea Mist also has some 'living' traits, but compared with that, the 'liveliness' of your ship is a bit too much."

"It brings unexpected convenience," Duncan said offhand.

Tyrian did not argue. After he watched the ship's movement for a moment, he could not help asking: "the Vanished is speeding up and changing course. What are you going to do?"

"I came to tell you that we are heading to Dagger Island."

"Dagger Island?" Tyrian froze for a moment, then reacted at once. "Something has happened there already?!"

“A Frostholm military ship exploded and sank on its way back to the main island. It had made a short stop at Dagger Island, and when it returned it had already become a carrier of corruption,” Duncan did not hide anything. “Now I suspect that the situation on Dagger Island may already have reached a runaway state. For some unknown reason, the whole alert system on the island has not reacted at all, and the Frostholm main island has not received any abnormal report.”

“…Penetrating corruption. Something has silently punched through the defenses on Dagger Island,” Tyrian understood at once, but right after that came strong disbelief. “But that… the defenses over there should not be that easy to pierce…”

“No defense system is flawless. Besides, corruption comes from the Deep Sea and is more likely tied to the Abyssal Lord,” Duncan shook his head. “The Frostholm authority should already be alarmed by that warship’s self-destruction, but I do not have much faith in them. I had better go take a look myself.”

“…Then what about me?” Tyrian thought for a moment and roughly understood what Father meant. “What do you need me to do?”

“I will send AI to take you back later. Bring your crew and stand by near Frostholm,” Duncan said after a brief pause, already having decided in his heart. “Prepare for the worst case.”

“The worst case?”

“The warship that suffered corruption sank, and it sank with an Anomaly speed,” Duncan said as he spoke, drawing useful memories and information out of the new body he had just taken over. “It was as if something under the sea was dragging it down…”

Tyrian’s expression slowly changed. A heavy look rose in his single eye. “You mean…”

“Since the Frostholm rebellion ended, half a century has passed. Let us assume that the ‘thing’ disturbed by the Abyssal Trench Project has never actually slept during those fifty years, but has been active all along, even consciously gathering strength,” Duncan looked toward the distant sea, his calm voice brewing a storm. “Tyrian, how many ships do you think have sunk into the waters near Frostholm in the past fifty years? Under that city-state… how many things might be hidden now?”

The deck fell silent.

Under the quiet, freezing veil of night, the Pirate Lord suddenly shivered.

…

A White Dove flew into the city. Deep in the cold, empty streets under curfew, a flash of ghostly green fire passed by.

A patrol squad of Guardians had just left this spot, and the citizens of the city would not come out at this hour of the night. No one noticed the sudden flicker of flame in the shadows of the alleyways, and no one noticed several strange figures stepping out from those shadows.

An old-looking house stood at a corner of Hearth Street.

It had gray outer walls, a dark sloped roof, a black front door, and a gas lamp with ironwork carvings fixed to the outer wall. It was a typical northern city-state building, and it looked like someone had been living here recently.

Morris took two steps forward and, by the light of the gas lamp, checked the house number beside the door.

This was indeed the residence Brown Scott had mentioned in his letter.

“I will go check first with Morris,” Duncan said to Vanna and Alice behind him. He wore a long black coat and a wide-brimmed hat. His voice came out from under the thick bandages, low and muffled. “You two wait nearby. Just do not alarm the patrolling Guardians.”

They did not need many people to check what was going on inside a house, and if this “Brown Scott” really was inside and able to talk, bringing too many people would only create more chances for trouble. After all, Duncan had not come tonight to cut down everyone in his way. He had come to gather information.

Chapter 329: Student

Alice and Vanna hid in the dark at the corner of the street. They would wait there for orders and keep an eye on the area around the building.

Duncan and Morris walked up to the building with the black front door.

The inside of the building was very quiet. That was only natural. The Sun had not yet risen, and this world's nights were never fit for an ordinary person to be out and about. Most normal people did not have much "night life" after nightfall. Going to bed early and waiting for morning was the rule.

But would a "replica" that had returned from the Deep Sea keep the same schedule as an ordinary person?

Duncan raised his head and noticed a clear button in the corner of the doorframe. He reached out and pressed it twice.

Faintly, they could hear the sharp, urgent ring of an electric bell from inside the building. In the stillness of the night, the bell sounded especially harsh.

"Maybe we should not be knocking on doors during curfew," Morris rubbed his forehead. His tone held a bit of doubt. "If we disturb a neighbor, it will draw suspicion."

"But your friend may not be able to wait much longer. It is better to be early," Duncan said calmly. "Do not worry about the rest. Making the Church suspicious or alarming the city-state authority is all just part of life. You should get used to being a member of the Vanished."

Morris opened his mouth but did not say anything. Duncan reached out again and pressed the doorbell twice more.

At last, they heard hurried footsteps from inside the building, along with the sound of something being knocked over. Then the light in the living room came on, and soft light spilled out onto the street through the nearby window.

The lock clicked. The black door opened a crack, and a wary eye peered out. At the same time, a young, nervous voice asked: “Who is it?”

It sounded like a young woman.

Duncan and Morris exchanged a glance. Duncan looked a little surprised, while Morris looked thoughtful, as if he had remembered something.

“Are you Galina?” Morris asked carefully. “Is Brown Scott Mr. at home? I am a friend of your Teacher’s.”

As he spoke, he turned toward Duncan and lowered his voice, speaking quickly: “That might be Brown Scott’s student. I heard him mention her.”

Duncan nodded in understanding. At the same time, the young woman behind the door clearly hesitated after hearing Morris’s words. Only after a moment did she speak again: “Sorry, it is very late, and Teacher is sleeping. Could you come back after sunrise?”

Morris frowned. The situation was not what he had expected. He had not thought that, six years after Brown Scott’s death, the man’s student would still be living in this house. But after a short pause, he found the right words. “We arrived too late and have not found a place to stay yet. Also, your Teacher wrote me a letter earlier. He invited me here.”

The old scholar paused for a moment, then went on: “My name is Morris Underwood. Your Teacher should have mentioned me.”

The voice inside fell silent. “Galina” seemed to be searching her memory. After several seconds, she spoke again: “Then… please wait a moment. I will open the chain.”

The sound of metal clinking and chain scraping came from behind the door. The person inside opened the safety chain that hung on the inner side, and the door finally swung open. In the warm, bright light, Duncan saw a tall, slightly strange figure.

She was only a few centimeters shorter than Vanna. Her height, almost one meter ninety, was striking. Unlike the tall but still slender Vanna, this young lady in the doorway had strong, powerful muscles visible all over her body. But what drew the eye even more than her height was her skin, which was gray-white like stone and traced with faint golden lines.

Aside from these obvious nonhuman traits, however, her face was no different from that of an ordinary young human woman. It even looked a bit… delicate.

Because she had just been woken from sleep in the middle of the night, this stone-like young lady wore only a loose nightgown. Her brown hair lay a little messy down her back. She held on to the doorframe and studied the two uninvited guests at her door with cautious eyes.

Just as Duncan was curiously looking her over, she was also looking curiously at Duncan: a broad-shouldered Visitor in a black coat and a wide-brimmed hat, with no facial features visible between the folds of clothing, only layers of bandages.

Even if people in Frostholm were used to “bandages,” this Visitor was still a bit too intimidating.

The muscles on her body tensed in a way that could be seen with the naked eye.

“Ah, I forgot to say,” Morris’s voice suddenly broke the tense, awkward mood. He turned to Duncan. “Brown’s student Galina is a Senkin. They really are not very common in the northern city-states.”

Then he looked back at Galina standing in the doorway: “This is Mr. Duncan. He is…”

“Morris’s friend, a traveling explorer. He is very interested in Mr. Brown Scott’s research, so he came by while passing through,” Duncan said first. “I hope we are not causing you any trouble.”

“…Teacher is resting. I do not know when he will wake up, but he did mention that Mr. Morris might come visit,” Galina said. Her soft, hesitant voice did not match her tall, strong body at all. It carried a kind of timid lack of confidence. When she spoke, she did not dare meet Duncan’s or Morris’s eyes. She muttered as she stepped aside. “Please come in. It is cold outside.”

Morris thanked her and stepped into the house with Duncan.

The turning of the hinges broke the silence of the night. The black door closed, and the street outside fell quiet again.

Just inside the entrance was a plain living room. The furniture looked like it had already been in use for at least ten or twenty years. One side of the living room opened into the kitchen and dining room. On the other side was a staircase leading up to the second floor. Under the stairs they could see a narrow door that likely led to a basement or wine cellar.

Under the bright electric light, no suspicious dark corners could be seen in the room. Everything in sight looked warm and… ordinary.

Duncan and Morris did not show too much curiosity. They only gave the room a quick look, then sat down in the living room under Galina’s

guidance. The tall Senkin lady went into the kitchen and began busily making tea and preparing some snacks.

“Would you like some sweet pancakes and sausages? That is all we have right now…” Galina called from the kitchen to her guests, her voice carrying a hint of apology.

“Just some hot water is fine. No need to trouble yourself,” Morris waved a hand. When Galina came back over, he asked a seemingly casual question, “By the way, have you been living here all this time?”

“Yes, I have always lived here,” Galina nodded. “Teacher went away on a trip for a while before. He gave me the key and asked me to look after the place for him. So I moved in from my old rented place and have stayed ever since. He came back recently, and I stayed here to keep taking care of him.”

“He went away for a while?” Morris frowned without thinking. “When was that?”

“…About five or six years ago,” Galina thought for a moment and answered without much certainty. Her face held a touch of shame. “I can never remember times very well. Teacher always scolds me for that.”

Morris and Duncan exchanged a look.

“When did Mr. Brown come back?” Duncan asked, as if in passing.

“About a month ago,” Galina answered in the same casual tone one used for small talk. “He came back all of a sudden and said he was tired from traveling and needed a good long rest… Oh, it was after that that he mentioned inviting Mr. Morris over as a guest.”

“I was very surprised when I got his letter,” Morris went on smoothly. “He had not contacted me in many years. The last news I received from him, many years ago, was that he was going to sea by ship… Ah, I think it was a small mail steamer called the Obsidian?”

As he spoke, he watched the person in front of him closely, without seeming to.

But Galina showed no reaction at all when she heard “the Obsidian.” She only thought for a moment, then shook her head: “I do not know about that. He did not tell me much when he went out…”

Her tone and expression as she answered were perfectly normal.

But her answer itself was clearly wrong.

She did not know which ship her Teacher had taken when he left!

For an ordinary teacher-student relationship, that might not mean anything. But her bond with that folklore scholar was clearly more than that. Brown Scott had trusted this student enough to hand over the key to his own home, and she had lived here for six full years. After “coming home,” Teacher had let her keep caring for him without any doubt. With a relationship that close and trusting, Brown could not possibly have left without telling Galina his travel plans.

Galina calmly met the Visitor’s eyes. Her expression was quiet and peaceful.

It was as if everything happening around her was only natural.

Chapter 330:

Morris made full use of his way with words. In the calm, casual talk, he used hints and side questions to confirm many things with Galina.

During the talk, he and Duncan slowly confirmed the state of this female apprentice.

All the memories about the shipwreck Brown Scott had suffered six years ago, and everything related to her mentor’s death after that, had completely vanished from Galina’s mind.

No, it was not only the memories that had vanished, but the whole chain of understanding that went with them.

A person’s death set off a chain of reactions. It included ripples in one’s social circle, the handling of affairs after death, a long period of remembrance and emotional swings, and all the tiny changes that would have built up in this house over six years. That was not something you could fix by simply deleting and replacing a piece of memory.

Yet in Galina’s understanding, “Brown Scott died in a shipwreck six years ago” had never happened at all. No trace of the follow-up chain of events remained either. She only felt it was natural that she had lived in this house for six years, quietly waiting for her teacher to return. And now, in her eyes, her teacher had already come back and was resting in the room upstairs.

The kettle’s sharp whistle suddenly sounded, cutting off the talk in the sitting room. Galina stood up at once and walked toward the kitchen: “Sorry, I need to turn off the stove.”

While the Senkin lady was away for a moment, Duncan looked up at Morris on the sofa opposite and said: “Her cognition has been interfered with.”

“We should check the whole building,” Morris said in a low voice. “If Brown really is here, he must have left something while he was still clear-headed. He even wrote me a second letter not long ago. At that time he had clearly already noticed some of the truth.”

“…Let Galina rest for a while,” Duncan said softly.

Morris nodded. While they spoke, Galina had already come back from the kitchen. She carried a large tray with warming ginger tea and some biscuits. The lady with stone-like gray-white skin set the tray on the coffee table, looked up at the two guests and said: “Thank you for waiting. Have some ginger tea to warm yourselves.”

“Thank you,” Morris said as he pointed to the sofa beside him. “Galina, sit here first, sit properly. I need to tell you something.”

“Ah… all right, Mr. Morris.” Galina felt a little strange, but faced with her mentor’s close friend, she still sat down at once as told. “What do you want to say?”

Morris fixed his gaze on Galina’s eyes and said: “Lomonosov Inequalities.”

Galina’s eyes snapped wide open. A vast flood of knowledge, memories, and logical problems instantly covered all her thoughts. Before she could even grasp the rough outline of this “storm of information”, a strong, self-protective drowsiness was already rising in her mind.

She silently fainted. Her snoring was steady, and her sleeping posture looked peaceful.

Duncan watched this with no expression. After two seconds of silence, he asked: “How long will she sleep?”

“Depends on intelligence. Heidi slept for twelve hours that time. Galina should sleep longer,” Morris shrugged. “Folklore scholars usually are not that good at mathematics.”

For a moment Duncan did not know what to say. After a long pause he finally asked: “Why did you use this trick on your own daughter?”

“Heidi insisted that her hypnosis skills had already surpassed mine, and a father sometimes has some strange competitiveness.”

Duncan thought for a moment and felt there was no need to continue this topic. He stood up and looked at the staircase leading to the second floor.

“Now we can take a proper look. If Galina did not lie, her teacher should be in the bedroom on the second floor.”

The old stairs creaked. Bright electric lights lit up the corridor on the second floor. Morris and Duncan climbed the stairs and began to search for the folklore scholar who had “returned to the Mortal Realm”.

The layout of the second floor was not complicated. A straight corridor connected every room, and most of the doors were not locked. Duncan and Morris quickly checked most of the rooms, then stopped in front of the last door on the left side of the corridor.

It was the only locked place on the whole second floor.

Morris stepped forward and tugged the doorknob. His brows furrowed slightly. “Locked. Bolted from inside.”

“Locked from inside?” Duncan felt a faint wrongness, then remembered something. “Galina just said she brought food to her teacher’s room every day…”

“Impossible. This door has not been opened for many days – a week or more,” Morris said at once. His eyes slowly swept over the door in front of

him, and faint light seemed to ripple in his gaze. “The lock also shows no sign of damage.”

“…So Galina only ‘believes’ she brings food to her teacher’s room every day, but in fact her teacher has not opened this door for many days,” Duncan said. He glanced back at the stairs leading down to the first floor. “The cognitive interference has kept going.”

Morris did not speak. He only raised his hand and gently knocked on the pale yellow door.

There was no answer from the room.

“Brown, it is me,” Morris called. “If you are inside, open the door. No matter what state you are in now, you do not need to worry. We can solve the trouble you have run into.”

There was still no answer.

Duncan quietly set his gaze on the door. He only felt that the situation… was not surprising.

In the end he gave a soft sigh. “Let me do it, Morris. We are probably still a step too late.”

Morris’s expression stiffened for a moment. He seemed to want to say something, but his lips trembled twice and he still said nothing. He only silently stepped aside.

Duncan did not use any fancy method. He just stepped forward and rammed the door. The ordinary wooden door, already not very solid, broke its lock with a loud bang and swung wide open.

A room almost completely wrapped in darkness appeared before them.

There was no light on in the room. The window facing the street also seemed to be blocked by something, so even the street lamps outside could

not shine inside. Only the light spilling in from the corridor lit a small patch near the door. In the shadows beyond, they could vaguely see some dim shapes covering the ceiling and floor.

Duncan stepped into the room first. He raised his right hand, and in his palm he held a cluster of ghostly green spirit form flame. With his other hand he felt for the light switch beside the door.

When the light came on, everything in the room finally became clear.

“This is…” Morris, who followed him in, saw the scene inside and cried out softly in shock.

Patches of some gray-black, mud-like substance lay all over the room. They covered the floor, corrupted the walls, and even clung firmly to the ceiling. In some places half-melted “mud” drooped down from the filth on the ceiling and hung in midair. They looked like twisted, swollen blood vessels, or some strangely shaped stalactites.

In an instant, Duncan thought of the scene he had seen in the hold of the Obsidian back then.

These strange, horrifying “mud” patches looked almost exactly the same as the situation in the Obsidian’s lower hold.

The muscles in Morris’s face tightened.

To be honest, from the very beginning he had not believed that his “old friend” had really returned to the Mortal Realm. He knew that behind this affair there had to be some kind of runaway state supernatural manifestation, one of those manifestations of the extraordinary, maybe even tied to the Deep Sea’s curse. But even though he had faintly expected it before they opened the door, seeing this scene with his own eyes still hit him hard.

“The Deep Sea’s replicas… it seems they all end up like this,” Duncan’s voice broke Morris’s daze. “In the end we still came a step too late. It is a pity.”

Morris blinked, then shook his head hard, as if to shake out the tangled thoughts in his mind. He walked deeper into the room, carefully stepping around the clumps of “mud” on the floor, and after a while stopped by a table.

This table was also covered in mud, and the largest heap of mud was piled between the table and the bed.

“…He wrote two letters. At least at that time he still had some sanity,” Morris said softly. “He must have noticed his own Anomaly…”

“His sanity lasted at least until the moment he locked this room from inside. After that he could no longer control what happened,” Duncan said as he came to the desk. He watched the hardened mud around them with a thoughtful look. “These replicas from the Deep Sea do not all seem the same. Some have no trace of sanity at all. Some even keep their original memories and can live for a while like an ordinary person. And some… are like the captain of the Obsidian, twisted completely into a monster, yet keeping his soul from beginning to end.”

“Like some kind of unstable experimental product?”

Morris said this offhand, and just then something suddenly entered his sight.

There was a sheet of paper. It was pinned under the edge of a hardened lump of mud that faintly held the shape of an arm.

“This is…” The old scholar’s eyes went wide. He gave a soft cry and carefully pulled the paper free. “Mr. Duncan, look at this!”

Duncan moved over at once. On the dirty paper, a few words that were no longer very clear came into his view.

“To the investigator, the following are the changes that happened to my body in its final stage:”

Chapter 331:

The paper was crumpled, and many parts had been corrupted by the gray-black “mud”. The writing on it was blurred and broken. But after Morris carefully worked on it, many sentences still recovered to a state that could barely be read.

“Brown Scott” had recorded the strange changes that happened to him in the last clear stage of his mind:

“…Around four in the morning, twelve hours after locking the door. The growing tinnitus and bouts of vertigo already affected my movements badly. I could only write something when my condition was slightly better. There seemed to be bleeding under the skin. I saw bruises appear for no reason…

“Half past six. My internal organs seemed to roll, as if the structures inside my body had lost all order and each had its own will, moving around on its own. I did not feel pain. Even the dizziness eased a lot… Fear began to fade. Clearer and clearer memories appeared in my mind…

“Around seven. I clearly remembered the details of my death and became more and more sure that the real me had long since died. My left leg broke for no reason – or perhaps a section of bone in the middle suddenly dissolved and vanished.

“Eight fifteen. The left leg began to dissolve. First the skin split open on its own. Then the tissue inside flowed out like some gray-black liquid. Those liquid parts that left the body seemed to have a life of their own, crawling

on the floor and even climbing up the walls… For a time I worried whether the boards I nailed over the window could block these strange and terrible substances. But later I found that once they left the body, they quickly lost their activity. Even while they still had activity, they seemed to consciously avoid sunlight… This may be very important information, so I record it here…

"…The heart stopped beating, yet consciousness still continued. I could feel that this body no longer worked by the normal physiological rules of humans at all. I tried to cut a wound. There was no blood in it, only gray-black viscous matter slowly flowing out… What material is this body made from now?

"The entire lower body began to dissolve. It took some effort to fix myself in one place and keep writing these words. I now cannot feel any pain. There is no breath, and the heartbeat had long since stopped. Now and then I can hear a buzzing noise, as if the substance that makes up myself is resonating… More and more of the viscous matter left the body, making a complete mess of the room…

"…I hope Galina will not be frightened when she cleans the room… Even though, as I write this name, I can hardly recall Galina's face in my mind.

"Half past ten. The thing I feared most began to happen. My vision quickly weakened. The world grew darker and darker. I have to feel along the edge of the paper and try to keep the writing below as clear as possible…

"Cannot tell the time now. It is probably between eleven and twelve. I heard a sharp, strange sound. It lasted about five minutes. After that, all the discomfort began to go away, and my sense of the remaining parts of the body also quickly weakened. I can faintly feel everything below the chest sinking down…

"Maybe another hour passed,"

The writing stopped here.

No one knew if the recorder's consciousness had finally reached its end, or if, after losing most of his senses, he could no longer place words on the paper. In the end this dead man left only a sudden full stop to the mortal world.

Morris stayed silent for a long time. After who knew how long, he finally spoke in a low, almost self-talking voice: "Ah, it really is his handwriting."

"Do you need some time alone?" Duncan gave the old mister a calm look. "I can wait outside."

"No need. I already mourned him once," Morris shook his head slightly. "I just did not expect to see his academic record again six years later. All this material is useful, right?"

Duncan did not answer at once. He leaned closer to the hardened, frozen "mud" and studied its edges with a thoughtful look. Then he picked up the record Brown Scott had left and carefully examined the places along the edge where the paper had been fully soaked by the mud.

The edges were blurred and uneven. The boundary between paper and mud seemed to have vanished, even showing signs of partial fusion.

"Have you found something?" Morris noticed what Duncan was doing.

"…elements," Duncan raised his head. "The Church in Frostholm is studying this substance. They think this sticky stuff left after a Deep Sea replicant collapses is in nature very close to the 'elements' spoken of by the Annihilators."

Morris was stunned for a moment, but by now he was somewhat used to the captain always having some new clue from who knew where. So he did not bother to ask where this information came from. After a short thought he

said: “I know this term ‘elements’. If you want to study the history of cultists, you can never avoid their mystical talk.”

He paused, as if sorting through the knowledge in his mind, then went on: “Just as the Suntists firmly believe that the true ancient Sun will save the world sooner or later, the Annihilators have a similar ‘salvation prophecy’. They preach that on some day in the future, the Abyssal Lord will awaken from sleep and in rage destroy this mortal world that the gods have twisted and deceived. The Abyssal Deep Sea that stands for the ‘true present world’, will then rise from the depths of the world and once again become a paradise where mortals can live. Before that day comes, ‘elements’ will first gush out in great quantity. elements is the keystone of the world, the blueprint of all things. It will cover everything and restore the world to its true form…”

Listening to the old scholar, Duncan stayed silent for a few seconds, then raised his head: “Gush out in great quantity… from the Deep Sea?”

Morris did not answer for a moment.

“I am more and more interested in those Annihilators now. But rather than their so-called ‘salvation prophecy’, I am more curious how they have built ‘contact’ with the place a thousand meters under Frostholm at this moment,” Duncan said, shaking his head. “replicas come from the Deep Sea. The Obsidian and that submersible off Dagger Island were both like this. But a group of mystical Annihilators… how do you think they are touching a power a thousand meters under the water?”

“…Even for a powerful city-state, building a submersible that can travel to a thousand meters in the Deep Sea is not a simple matter. At the very least, it is not something a band of cultists could master,” Morris said in thought. “But they can use some indirect ritual to guide the Deep Sea’s power mentally, or to contact the Deep Sea’s… ‘mighty beings’.”

“So Frostholm must have a larger Cult base, a hidden place where they can hold large rituals,” Duncan said slowly. “It would be enough for them to keep stirring the power in the Deep Sea, creating replicants in the city-state and even invading Dagger Island.”

As he spoke, he raised his head and looked around the room. The only window was nailed shut with boards, and the ceiling, walls, and floor were all covered with dried mud that had lost its life. Every mark here seemed to tell, without words, of a shocking struggle and a decision to die.

And in his perception, the Vanished was already under sail, heading toward Dagger Island and Frostholm’s main island.

“Maybe in the end we still have to give the cultists here a little ‘Vanished shock’.” He said this softly. He rubbed his fingers together, and a small tuft of ghostly green flame fell from his fingertips, dropped to the floor without a sound, and quickly melted into the air and disappeared.

Of course Morris saw this, but he said nothing. He only gave the table beside him one last look.

That was where Brown Scott had last “worked”. Perhaps he had only been a short-lived replicant, but when that ever-collapsing body bent over the desk and wrote furiously, it still held a noble soul.

“…How do we deal with things here?” The old scholar raised his head and looked at the captain. “The marks in the room, the data Brown left, and… Galina downstairs.”

“We have already gained enough clues. Leave the rest to the people of Frostholm,” Duncan said calmly. “Keep the room as it is. Leave that letter in a visible place on the table, then prepare a denunciation letter. As for Galina…”

Duncan paused.

“The cognitive interference attacking Galina has clearly not ended. Even after the replicant in this building vanished, she has shown no sign of waking up. She even still believes her teacher is resting in the room. That means the ‘source’ that causes the interference is not her teacher, but something still active, hiding deep in the city-state. If we do not destroy that source, she will never truly recover.”

As he said this, he frowned slightly, as if he had thought of more.

“And we also do not know how many ‘Brown Scotts’ and how many ‘Galinas’ are still in this city-state.”

Morris’s expression froze. “You mean…”

“Rumors of the dead returning spread through the city, yet at the same time completely opposite news reached Tyrian,” Duncan glanced at Morris. “This city-state has probably been riddled through by replicants and cognitive interference like a sieve.”

Chapter 332: The Tailing Duo

In the whole house, aside from the last room where Brown Scott had been, they did not find anything that could be called an Anomaly.

In fact, even that room the gray black sludge had corrupted no longer held any trace of the supernatural. Aside from the visual shock brought by those bizarre sludge-like masses, there was not the slightest supernatural power left anywhere in the building.

Everything that did not belong to the mortal world had vanished along with Brown Scott.

On the first floor of the house, Galina still slept. The tall Senkin woman, her skin like stone, leaned in the corner of the sofa. Her sleeping posture was calm and gentle, her face relaxed.

In her dreams, she was still a student studying under her Teacher, still living quiet, ordinary days. Her learned and kind Teacher had just finished many years of travel and had recently returned home, ready to tell her many, many stories about faraway places.

“If only Heidi were here. She would mix some potions that would at least make this young lady feel a bit better when she woke up,” Morris lowered his head to look at Galina on the sofa, his expression a little complicated. “I can tell she was very close to Brown.”

“…The gloom will pass,” Duncan said. He fell silent for a moment, rummaged in his pocket, and took out a small crystal pendant. He brought it

to his lips and whispered something to it, then pressed it into Galina's hand. "Have a good dream. Everything will get better."

Morris quietly watched what Duncan did. After a long time, he finally could not help speaking: "You even brought those pendants over here?"

"…I stocked up too many last time. I had half a box left that I really couldn't sell. No one even wanted them as gifts," Duncan said. His face looked expressionless (mostly because the bandages hid it), and his tone was flat. "So I figured I'd hand them out while traveling later… do you want one?"

"No, thanks," Morris hurriedly waved his hand. "This kind of feminine jewelry doesn't really suit me."

"Oh, right."

…

The night wind blew through the dark, deathly quiet alley. In the faint glow cast over from the gas lamp at the corner, Vanna watched the surroundings with sharp, alert eyes.

Alice stood at her side and tried her best to mimic her, looking around as well, but it was obvious Alice had no idea what Vanna was actually watching for.

"The street is so quiet. There's no one at all," probably because she was not used to such a silent, oppressive place, the doll finally could not help speaking. "Miss Vanna, what are you always looking at?"

Vanna answered in a calm tone: "Any supernatural beings that might appear, or suspicious shadows clinging around that building, if there are any."

"Huh?" Alice froze for a moment. "Will there be?"

“…What do you think Mr. Duncan asked us to stand by out here for?”

Alice thought about it and said: “Because he thinks I get in the way?”

Vanna said: “…You’re right.”

Vanna felt it would be hard to explain anything clearly to this solid wooden head, so she simply chose not to.

But she herself understood very well why they were keeping watch here.

A “replica” that had returned from the Deep Sea had been moving around the city-state for many days, and that replica had been living in the building not far away. The Annihilators who followed the Abyssal Lord could not possibly ignore that.

It was even possible that they had been the ones pulling the strings behind this whole affair.

Mr. Duncan and Mr. Morris had gone to investigate the situation inside that house. They were there to investigate, but also to bait a trap. Would any cultists be watching this place? Would the power that had sent “Brown Scott” back make a move tonight? Would shadows lurk in this street? If uninvited guests appeared, would those shadows still stay put?

Vanna controlled her own breathing and heartbeat, drew in her presence and power, and when she had confirmed that the street was still quiet, she once again hid herself beneath the building’s shadows.

Then she saw Alice beside her suddenly think of something and lean forward. The next moment, the doll raised her hands, cupped her own head and gave it a shake, then popped it off with a little “pop”. With one hand on the wall and her head held up in the other, she leaned out at the corner and swayed it back and forth toward the street.

Even a battle-hardened Inquisitor could not stop her eyes from twitching at that sight. Vanna stared, lowered her voice, and said: “What are you doing?!”

After Alice finished wobbling her head at the corner, she heard Vanna’s voice, hurriedly pulled her head back, and popped it back into place with another little “pop”. She looked completely innocent: “I was checking what was happening across the street…”

“Next time you have a plan like that, at least tell me in adv—” Vanna glared at the doll across from her, but halfway through the sentence she swallowed the rest, waved a tired hand, and said: “Forget it. Never mind.”

Alice looked completely baffled, but just as she was about to speak, she seemed to sense something again and could not help glancing outside: “Miss Vanna, I keep feeling… like someone is nearby, but I can’t see anyone.”

“Someone nearby?” Vanna became alert at once. She did not relax just because Alice usually seemed unreliable. Instead she tensed every nerve, sensing the aura around them as she asked in a low voice: “Where?”

“Just diagonally across, under that street lamp,” Alice whispered as well. To show how careful she was being, she even crouched down while she pointed toward the mouth of the alley. “But I only saw the strings, not the person.”

At first Vanna did not react. She only looked in the direction Alice was pointing. Two seconds later she suddenly froze, turned back to stare at the doll, and said: “Strings? What strings?”

“The strings on people, of course. Everyone has them. They float from their bodies up into the sky,” Alice said, gesturing as she spoke, her tone

completely matter-of-fact. “There are some behind the head, and on the hands and feet too…”

She suddenly paused, then added: “Oh, right, Mr. Duncan doesn’t have any – though he is Mr. Duncan, so that’s normal…”

As Alice talked, her voice finally grew hesitant and trailed off.

Slow as she was, she finally noticed the strange look on Vanna’s face.

“…You can’t see them?” The doll hesitated and came up with the only explanation she could think of. “Uh, then I won’t laugh at you. The captain said people’s eyes aren’t all the same…”

“…I can’t see them, but this isn’t the time to talk about that,” Vanna snapped fully awake and forced her attention back to the street lamp not far away. “Are those strings still there?”

She knew what mattered most right now.

Alice could see invisible “strings” floating on human bodies, and she had always taken it for granted that this was normal and that everyone else could see them too. Because she took it so much for granted, this fact had only just slipped out now because of an offhand remark. This might well be the special power she had as Anomaly 099, or it might have some deeper, stranger explanation behind it. But either way, none of that was something they should be studying right now.

Someone was hiding nearby, and now he – or they – had already been exposed to the doll’s sight. That was what mattered.

“They’re still there, and they’re swaying a little side to side,” Alice whispered, glancing up at the area around the lamp across the way. Then she frowned. “Ah, it looks like a few of them are gone?”

“A few are gone?” Vanna’s heart gave a sudden jolt. The next second, vigilance surged up inside her. Years of battle-honed instinct and the crisis premonitions granted by the Goddess exploded together in her senses, making her snap her gaze toward a certain point deeper in the street.

In a patch of eerie shadow where the street lamps could not reach, darkness writhed and suddenly took shape.

In almost an instant, a gaunt, skeletal phantom appeared there. Right after it, a deformed freak linked to that skeletal shadow by chains also emerged –

It was a person, or at least the outline was still human. Yet his body had long since twisted and swollen into a horrifying state. His skin looked as if it had been scorched by fierce fire, charred and curled. His bones had grown out of order, forming broken plates along the surface of his body. Sharp bone spurs jutted and spread from his back, like the remains of some Deep Sea monster. Where his face should have been, there was only a hollow depression, within which a dim red glow flickered.

With just one glance, Vanna knew what this thing was. It was an Annihilation Priest who had already entered a deep symbiotic pact with Abyssal Demons and “purified” his own body to an extreme degree.

Annihilators regarded their flesh-and-blood bodies as cages forged by the gods. The way they pledged loyalty to the Abyssal Lord was by constantly using the power of Demons to reshape their own bodies, “purifying” their forms. This process gave them more and more Demonic traits and made them less and less like humans.

Once an Annihilator had purified himself far enough, his limbs mutated to a degree that even a temporary Transmutation spell could no longer turn him back into human shape, and he could no longer move among human society. He then had to rely on lower-ranking cultists to serve and feed him.

In return, however, he gained far greater power, as well as a stronger, more direct connection to the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea.

These cultists really were watching this place!

The thought flashed through Vanna’s mind, and in the same instant her body leaped high into the air.

To be able to move freely inside the city-state, she had not brought that steel greatsword of divine blessing.

But for a loyal priest of the Storm Goddess, a “sword” was not such an inconvenient thing.

The air compressed. Moisture gathered. The breath of sea and wind condensed in her hands into a blade of solid ice – just barely enough, but usable.

“Heretic!”

Chapter 333: Taking Action

With a fierce, exhilarating leaping strike that gathered the northern chill and the thunderous power born of the storm, and with a sense of pressure finally being released, Vanna’s body soared high. An icy blade had already formed in her empty hands, and in the cold radiance of the World’s Wound, the Vice Admiral’s sword came crashing down.

The air tore open. The nearby airflow twisted into blazing heat under the violent impact. By the time the blade had fallen halfway, it even began to take on a plasma-like texture, like roaring flames coiling around the ice-forged edge. The sight of ice and fire interwoven was so eerie and magnificent that even the cultist who looked like a Demon visibly froze for a moment.

For this Annihilation Priest, this should have been a successful ambush. He had noticed the uninvited guests ahead of time and used a spell to hide his own aura. His Demon body, fused by a deep symbiotic pact, could even let him completely stop his breathing and heartbeat for a short time. Yet this concealment that should have been flawless somehow got exposed and alerted his target.

The prey that should have been his target had now turned into a ferocious beast striking back – and that beast’s strength far exceeded his expectations.

The massive blade wreathed in great force came crashing down. The Annihilation Priest had no time at all to counterattack. He could only throw everything into a strange, piercing shriek. Compressed inside that scream

was a powerful spell. Layers of black bone plates and rocklike shields rose up from all directions in an instant to block Vanna's falling path.

At the same time, the Abyssal Demon made of jagged bone shards moved under the drive of the pact to stand in front of its master, opening its mouth toward Vanna as it prepared to unleash a powerful corrosive breath.

Only at this moment did the shape of the skeletal Demon fully condense out of the shadows – it was actually a Abyssal Hound, a size larger than Dog.

Vanna had no intention of slowing down or dodging.

"Boom!"

A thunderous crash shattered the peace of the veil of night, laced with a string of tooth-grinding, sharp, tearing noises.

With one leaping chop, Vanna smashed the energy barrier and rock shields that the Abyssal Deep priest had summoned, along with the Abyssal Hound's corrosive breath and half of the Demon's dog-like head, all into flying shards.

The shock wave swept through the alley like a cutting gale, clearing away dust and smoke in an instant. The Abyssal Hound, now with only half a head left, shrieked as it was flung backward. The symbiotic pact chains dragged the Annihilation Priest with it for more than ten meters. They rolled along the ground together for a long while before finally stopping and struggling to get back up.

The heretic priest's twisted, mutated body trembled violently. The backlash from the symbiotic pact when his Demon was badly wounded made it hard for him to think. That deformed body hunched in the dimness, and for a moment it was hard to tell which one was the Demon and which had once been human – him, or the Abyssal Hound beside him.

The Abyssal Hound beside him staggered to its feet as well. Even with half its head cut off, the Demon's powerful vitality still kept it from dying. It let out a muddled low growl toward Vanna, while the damaged bone plates on its body clattered down one after another.

Vanna walked forward with no expression, casually tossing aside the long ice sword that had already shattered into pieces from the impact.

That thing had been meant to be disposable from the start, made just for a perfect, full-score leaping chop. Now it had fulfilled its mission.

The Annihilation Priest across from her barely lifted his head, struggling with all he had to clear his mind. Obscure, difficult Demonic whispers spilled from his mouth.

The power of a spell condensed into form. A twisted mass of bone and stone laden with rot appeared in the air in front of him and howled toward Vanna like a cannon shell.

Vanna raised one hand and caught the "shell" by force. She ignored the wisps of smoke that quickly rose from her palm and moved forward at the same pace. With her other hand she grabbed the half-head of the Abyssal Hound, which still seemed a bit dazed, and casually stuffed that "rotting projectile" into the neck cavity exposed by its missing skull.

The Abyssal Demon struggled wildly on instinct. Yet the strength that could have flipped a Steam Tank could not budge Vanna's arm. In its thrashing, it tore off the rest of its own head, while the "rotting projectile" it had summoned with its own power had already been forced into its own belly by Vanna. The bone plates layered inside the Demon's body gave off a crisp, continuous cracking sound, then quickly filled with bright light.

Vanna lifted a foot and kicked the soon-to-explode Demon away. Then she grabbed the Annihilation Priest beside it and casually yanked him up,

holding him in front of her like a shield.

In this lightning-fast exchange, the latter had no idea what was happening.

With a thunderous bang, the Abyssal Hound she had kicked away exploded violently in midair. Bone fragments raked through the alley like shrapnel, and the Annihilation Priest in Vanna's hands was instantly riddled through like a sieve.

But he was not dead yet. He only convulsed and curled up under the fierce, sudden pain.

The entire clash had been very short.

"Your symbiotic pact Demon is dead. Judging by how far your body has mutated, you have about six minutes of life left," Vanna said. She tossed the Cult priest onto the ground and set her boot on the place that was probably his head. "I know your sort would never say a word even if someone left you alive, but I still decided to try. You have three minutes to give your last words. That will decide the way you spend the other three minutes dying."

On the other side, Alice at the entrance of the alley understood even less. She only stared wide-eyed as she watched Vanna trade a flurry of blows with a suddenly appearing enemy, casually smash a hideous thing that looked like some distant relative of Dog, and then leave the attacker seemingly on the verge of dying.

She had no idea what had just happened, but it was obvious that Vanna was very strong.

So the doll grew excited, clapping her hands hard: "Miss Vanna, you're amazing!"

But in that moment of distraction, she seemed to forget that a few "strings" were still floating under the street lamp across the way.

The air near the entrance of the alley twisted.

A second attacker had been hiding in the shadows.

Vanna's fight with the Annihilation Priest had been too swift. What happened in the alley had gone beyond what the attackers expected, and the priest's companion had not had any chance to help. Now this hidden second cultist had just arrived – at a very bad time.

With the twist of the air, a short but sturdy figure appeared near Alice. He had rushed here in a hurry, only to see Vanna deep inside the alley already stepping on the Annihilation Priest's head.

The cultist froze for a moment. He looked up at the brutal scene inside, then over at the blonde woman beside him, who had just reacted and was now looking his way with a curious expression.

The next second, the short, stocky man turned and ran without the slightest hesitation.

But he had only taken two steps when a voice sounded from behind him: "Hey! Wait!"

He suddenly felt as if something had yanked him. That pulling force tugged at every joint in his body, making him hang in place as if a huge power were dragging on him.

The cultist turned his head in shocked fear. He saw black smoke rising in the air beside him. The Abyssal Demon that shared his symbiotic pact seemed to want to struggle out and manifest to fight back, but something held it down in the shadows so tightly that it could not take shape at all. He turned his head further and saw the woman with long golden hair in a dress looking at him, her hand stretched into the air as if she were grabbing something invisible.

“Don’t go yet,” Alice said. She held on to the “strings” and stared at the cultist who was trying to run, doing her best to make her expression look a bit intimidating. “The captain said people like you are all bad. We can’t just let you go – you’ll go hurt other people.”

Not far away, the Annihilator who had just run out of the alley now hung frozen in midair in a bizarre, almost comical posture. His head had already twisted back to a frightening angle. He stared in fear at the blonde woman at the alley mouth. Driven by his instinct to survive, he seemed to break free of that “pulling” sensation just a little, and at once he put all his strength into flicking his wrist.

A prepared piece of rune paper slipped out from his sleeve.

“Choose life… and devour…”

He forced the words out with difficulty, his throat mixing them with obscure Demonic whispers. The pre-stored spell activated. The rune paper burst into flame before it even hit the ground and began to seek out targets to attack according to its master’s command.

Within a certain range, every living person.

The rune paper burned away quickly in the flames. Nothing happened.

The cultist stared, eyes wide, watching this in terrified disbelief.

Alice also widened her eyes not far away, watching the scene in confusion.

She had neither breath nor heartbeat.

And she had no idea what had just happened.

But she belatedly reacted soon enough – that cultist had apparently tried to kill her just now.

She felt a little scared, so she tugged hard on the “strings” in her hand: “The captain said when I go out, I have to protect myself.”

The cultist’s body went completely rigid at once. The little bit of “freedom” he had just managed to regain was stripped away, and even his wrists and lips could no longer move. A strange numbness began to spread. He felt his body quickly growing stiff, cold, and… no longer like flesh and blood.

The world in his eyes went dark.

But in the next second, something seemed to appear within that darkness.

A hollow, deep voice that seemed to come straight from a chest cavity sounded in his ears –

“Ah, a new Attendant has arrived.”

Chapter 334: Alice Manor

The new attendant had arrived.

It was as if that single sentence triggered some kind of mechanism. With a low, muffled rumble sounding in his ears, countless vague shapes suddenly appeared in the darkness before the Annihilator's eyes. Faint light of unknown origin flickered into the air, lighting up a broad yet ancient and elegant hall inside an Anomaly.

He stared with wide eyes. The hall was as splendid as a royal palace, yet it also looked as if it had been abandoned for decades. At the far end, a curved staircase spiraled upward, linking the high gallery and platform. Huge pillars stood dimly in the gloom, and fine draperies hung from their tops, swaying gently in a breeze that came from nowhere.

Dark, hollow windows lined the walls around the hall. Each opening looked like the gaping maw of some great beast. No light shone outside them, and the windows themselves were sealed tight by crisscrossing steel bars. Enormous oil paintings hung between the windows. The canvases showed no clear figures or landscapes, only eerie, colorful patches that made the skin crawl.

The Annihilator stared in shock at the scene before him. Then he suddenly realized that the restraints on his hands and feet had vanished at some point. He took two steps forward and felt his body return to his control. Instinctively, he called out to the demon that had formed a symbiotic pact with his soul.

However, only a hollow howling echoed in his soul. The Abyssal demon that had been with him for many years now felt as if it had never existed at all. Nothing answered his call.

“Attendant, step forward. Come to the end of the carpet.”

The low, muffled voice rang out again, this time coming directly from inside his head.

“Who is it?!” The Annihilator looked around in terror at the grand yet empty and uncanny mansion hall, but he saw no one.

He raised his head again and looked to the far end of the hall. A dark red carpet stretched from his feet into the distance. At the far end of the carpet stood the staircase, spreading along a graceful curve like a pair of wings that joined the second floor.

For some reason, the moment he looked that way, his legs started to move on their own. As if obeying the voice he had just heard, he walked toward the end of the carpet and stopped a few meters short of the stairs.

A figure suddenly appeared there.

It was a body dressed in a black formal suit – a body with no head.

The body stood straight in front of the stairs. The suit on it was perfectly neat. A folded handkerchief peeked from the breast pocket, and a thin gold chain of a pocket watch hung from the other side. In one hand, it held a brass bell. The other hand stretched forward. In that pose, it looked exactly like a trusted butler welcoming a new recruit into the manor.

But he had no head. On that body in the black suit there was only a bare neck, like the joint where a doll’s head should have been.

“W-Where… where is this place?!”

The new attendant spoke in a trembling voice. He could no longer remember why he had come into this sealed mansion, nor could he remember his own name or past. All he felt was a primal fear, and a strange wrongness that was slowly corrupting his heart. He looked at the headless butler in front of him and forced himself to ask his question. As his voice rang out, whispers and the feeling of unseen eyes turned toward him from every side.

In shock, he turned his head and looked around the hall.

Figures in attendants' and maids' uniforms were hurrying about. They were clearly the servants who took care of this huge mansion. Whenever these servants passed the foot of the staircase, they paused, as if curiously eyeing the new recruit.

Low voices of conversation came from deep inside their chests – because every one of these servants had no head.

Above their necks there was only a smooth round knob, like the joint piece of a doll, with a texture somewhere between wood and porcelain.

The new attendant stared in disbelief at the servants moving back and forth in the hall, feeling dazed.

Had there been this many people here before? When he first came into this hall, had it really been so busy?

"This is Alice Manor, and you are the new attendant here," the butler's dull voice suddenly said, snapping the new attendant out of his daze. "Come with me. Your post from now on is upstairs."

The new attendant nodded without thinking and stepped after the headless butler. Without meaning to, he glanced down and saw that, at some point, he too was wearing an attendant's uniform – just like the footmen in the hall.

His mind grew more and more muddled. More and more of his memories were drawn out of this body, as if they were “no longer needed” – impurities that only got in the way of him carrying out a servant’s duties in this mansion.

With every step he took up the stairs, his hesitation and doubt grew weaker. At first, he still vaguely remembered that he did not belong here. Then he only remembered that he seemed to be trapped in a strange mansion. By the time he was only a few steps from the second floor, all he remembered was the butler’s instructions to him –

He stepped onto the last stair, lifted his head, and looked at the platform before him and the corridor running along its inner side.

A few servants were walking along the corridor. Even though they had no eyes, the new attendant could still feel their gaze on him.

“Why is everyone looking at me?”

“Because you are the first servant here who still has a head,” the butler stopped, turned around, and there seemed to be a hint of a smile in his voice. “And it has been many years since we last had a new recruit.”

“What am I supposed to do?” the new attendant asked carefully.

“Serve our Mistress and become one of us here. You will naturally know what you should do. But before that, you should go and greet the Mistress first…”

The butler slowly raised his arm and pointed at a black door at the end of the corridor.

“Go on. Push that door open and pay your respects to the Mistress.”

The new attendant nodded and turned to walk toward the door.

His steps were steady, and his expression slowly became calm. The way his limbs moved little by little grew as stiff and mechanical as those of the servants in the hall. He reached the door and raised both hands. His calm gaze swept over his wrists, which had already turned into round joints. He pressed lightly, and the door swung open.

The puppet took a step forward.

Inside the elegant bedroom, which could almost be called enormous, a gorgeous large bed stood in the center. Patterned curtains and tasseled drapes hung down around it. A silver-haired doll lay quietly on the bed, deep in dreamwalking sleep.

Beyond the bed, at the far end of the bedroom where a wall should have been, there was only a wide, boundless darkness. It seemed to lead into some distant, deep space. There, floor, walls, and ceiling all broke apart in jagged pieces. Chaotic shadows of darkness and countless tiny lights far away slowly rose and fell, turning into strange, shifting illusions of light and color. They stirred silently at the end of the bedroom and murmured faintly in the dark.

That surging darkness and those tiny lights looked like the doll’s bizarre, colorful dream, yet also like some formless thing trying to invade the mansion, held back outside the Mortal Realm by the doll’s sleep.

The new attendant, now turned into a puppet, stood in the bedroom doorway. Its eyes were dull as it stared at the beautiful doll sleeping soundly on the bed and at the heaving darkness behind her. Then it bent at the waist and bowed deeply to the Mistress.

Several bright threads stretched out from its limbs, drifting in the air for a moment before vanishing from sight.

The new attendant stayed bent at the waist and slowly backed out of the room. The door of the chamber where Alice slept slammed shut before it with a deep, solemn boom.

But there would never again be any change of expression on this attendant's face.

Still bent over, the puppet took a handkerchief from its pocket and gently dusted the ornaments near the door.

…

"Thud -"

"Crash -"

The sound of a heavy object hitting the ground rang out at the mouth of the alley. The Annihilator who had just tried to run suddenly dropped from midair. He hit the ground with a loud noise, and his body shattered at once into dozens of pieces like porcelain. Even his clothes were no exception.

There was not a trace of blood on the broken porcelain pieces. It was as if he had always been nothing more than a fired doll, and that a body of flesh and blood had only been his lifelong illusion.

Alice jumped in fright. "Waaah!"

A gust of wind roared behind her as Vanna rushed to the mouth of the alley. She stared, dumbfounded, at the scene before her, then after a long moment turned to the doll at her side. "This… was you?"

"…I don't know," Alice blinked and slowly glanced back. "Um… probably?"

"What do you mean, probably?!"

“I mean I grabbed his strings and then pulled a bit – he struck first, I got a little scared…” Alice babbled, waving her hands as she spoke. Her explanation worked wonders; in just a few sentences she made Vanna even more confused. “Did you get that?”

“…Not at all,” Vanna shook her head, then glanced toward the depths of the alley. There, a charred lump of remains was still giving off thin black smoke. “Damn it. The priest I dealt with never opened his mouth in the end, and yours just shattered. We did not get any information at all.”

“So that means the captain is going to be unhappy?”

“We don’t have time to worry about that. We need to leave,” Vanna said quickly. “We made too much noise. Even if this isn’t the city center, the night patrols should already be on their way.”

As she spoke, she raised her head and looked at the mansion not far away.

Chapter 335: No Longer Real

The fight in the alley had been fierce but short. From the moment the two cultists' movements were exposed to the end of the battle, only a few minutes had actually passed. But Vanna believed that in those few minutes they had made enough noise to draw the night guardians over.

Of course, whether in terms of position or strength, she was not afraid of Frostholm's guardians – but this was not the time to start extra trouble.

Just as she was wondering how to signal Duncan, who had gone into the building, that dark, heavy door happened to open.

Duncan and Morris appeared in the light.

In the next second, Duncan strode quickly toward the alley where Vanna and Alice were. Morris, meanwhile, turned back to close the door and traced patterns in the air above it, patterns that looked like ancient letters, as if he were offering a prayer to the God of Wisdom to call on some extraordinary power.

"I sensed the commotion outside," Duncan came to stand before Vanna and Alice, glanced up at the alley, frowned slightly, and asked quickly, "What happened?"

"As we expected, there were indeed Annihilators watching this place – Alice noticed their traces, and we fought with them for a short time," Vanna answered at once. "Both heretics are dead, no one escaped. But the noise from the fight may have drawn the guardians. They will be here soon."

“Alice noticed them?” Duncan glanced in surprise at the doll girl beside him, then saw the strange look on Vanna’s face and realized what had just happened was probably much more complicated than it sounded. He did not press for details, only nodded quickly. “No time for talk now. Get ready to move.”

“I have already erased the traces we left,” Morris had finished cleaning up and walked over. “When Galina wakes up, she will forget everything from the past twenty-four hours. Even a very skilled psychiatrist digging through her memories should not be able to recover much.”

“Good.”

Duncan nodded slightly. He did not actually care much about hiding his tracks, but having fewer people get in the way at the start of an operation certainly was not a bad thing.

Then he raised his hand and made a calling gesture into the darkness.

The flapping of wings broke the stillness of the night. The White Dove that had been perched on a nearby rooftop swooped toward them. A second later, a ghostly green flame flashed through the alley, and only the sound of beating wings was left, fading away into the veil of night.

The streets and alleys fell quiet again. Only after a few more minutes did a series of hurried footsteps and the swinging light of consecrated lanterns appear on the distant street.

…

Ai did not go very far – in fact, it only flew to the next block and found a place to land near an old factory.

It was a small corrugated-iron hut that no one lived in.

The metal hut leaned against the old factory. One of its windows had a hole, not too big and not too small. Ai slipped through the gap into the hut. As the spirit form flame flared up, the figures of Duncan and the other three appeared inside.

Vanna quickly looked around. Thick dust lay over the old hut. In one corner there was a plank bed and a simple table with chairs. A pile of odds and ends lay heaped on the other side of the room. The cold wind howled outside, and the hole in the nearby window let out a whining sound in the gusts.

“It is for pump-room maintenance workers to rest in. Outside inspection periods, no one usually stays here – though I don’t know when the inspection period is, at least today this is a place we can use for a while,” Vanna said as she walked to the window. She looked outside through the dirty glass. The old factory not far away stood silent in the veil of night. The lights in the plant were clear, and she could hear the sound of machines running inside. “The factory is still operating. A factory that runs day and night like this will certainly have a priest on duty. If an extraordinary fight breaks out in the nearby streets, the plant’s alert level will go up as well.”

“That won’t be a big problem. We just won’t light anything. They won’t be able to sense us here anyway,” Duncan said casually. “We’ll stay here until dawn before we move again – is that all right?”

As he spoke, he glanced at the three people in his view.

Alice was a cursed doll. Vanna was a strong, beautiful maiden. Even Morris, the older gentleman who looked the weakest, was an extraordinary who commanded many kinds of divine magic. In terms of strength, Duncan did not need to worry about them. He only wondered if the cold winter night in this northern city-state would be too harsh on an old mister like Morris.

“Don’t worry,” Morris obviously noticed Duncan’s glance. He smiled slightly and drew in front of his chest the Sacred Sigils granted by the God of Wisdom Rahm. “Until just two years ago, I often went to explore ancient ruins and cursed wasteland realms at the edge of dangerous seas. The conditions there were far harsher than here. Scholarly research has never been easy work, especially when it deals with history.”

Duncan thought for a moment and felt that the old mister was right.

In this world, being a historian or a folklorist really was a tough job. Even scholars who preferred to stay at home needed a few powerful tricks up their sleeves. After all, they ended up fighting the very things they were researching every so often. cursed books and bewitched relics were not the sort of things that sat quietly in display cases.

All the more so for an all-rounder scholar like Morris – Duncan suspected the man had probably mastered hand-to-hand combat and survival in the wild long before he ever turned to studying history…

“We could also get in touch with the informants Captain Tyrian placed in this city,” Vanna said at the side. “They should be able to help arrange lodging and provide information…”

“I’ll contact them, but not yet,” Duncan waved his hand, then his expression grew a little more serious. “From today on, whenever we deal with anyone in Frostholm, we have to be ready to examine them carefully. That includes the so-called ‘informants’ Tyrian mentioned.”

Vanna froze for a second, then realized what he meant. “You have confirmed that ‘Brown Scott’…”

“He was a Deep Sea replica, and he had already broken down on his own. We were a step too late and only found a few clues he left behind,” Duncan said, shaking his head. “But we had more or less expected that. Besides

that, we saw a female apprentice in that house whose memory and understanding were in complete chaos – she is an ordinary person."

Vanna's expression immediately turned serious as well.

"She is Brown's student, named Galina. In her memories and understanding, all parts related to her mentor dying in a shipwreck have already been completely erased," Morris said from the side. "And in the captain's and my judgment, this kind of thing… may no longer be an isolated case in Frostholm."

"From a little more than half a month ago, Tyrian started to receive strange and contradictory reports," Duncan continued. "Sometimes the reports said there were cases of 'the dead returning' in Frostholm. Sometimes they said it was all rumors and that the so-called dead had been normal residents of Frostholm from the very start. At times, these completely opposite reports even came from the same informant. At first, Tyrian thought this was the authorities of Frostholm controlling the flow of information, that the church was stepping in to reduce the impact of the strange events on the residents. But now it seems… it is very likely caused by confusion in people's minds."

"Captain Tyrian's informants are spread all across Frostholm… you mean this is a corruption of cognition and memory that covers the entire city-state?!" Vanna realized how serious this was. "Then right now in this city-state…"

"No one can say how many people are replicants and how many are originals. And that's the lesser problem. replicas shouldn't escape my eyes. Once I meet them, I can tell quickly. The real trouble is the ordinary people who are already not normal…" Duncan said. He paused, thought for a short moment, then shook his head. "In short, the informants Tyrian left in this city are no longer that reliable. Some of them may already have been

replaced. Some may have had their minds twisted. Some might even now be eyes and ears for the Annihilators… when we contact them, we must be cautious.”

Vanna nodded solemnly – but in her eyes, a spark of joy was slowly rising.

A cold, mysterious northern city-state. Residents constantly being replaced. The spies once planted in the city no longer to be trusted. Ordinary citizens who looked harmless and normal slowly growing warped memories and minds. Unreliable voices filling the whole city as corruption spread under the surface –

This was good, because everything here fell right back into her area of expertise.

Eliminating heretics. Purifying corruption.

She was beginning to understand another reason Pope Helena had sent her to serve aboard the Vanished.

Pland, where the Church had already secured a peaceful veil of night, no longer needing a inquisitor like her. But as long as she stayed with the Vanished, she would always have a stage where she could fully use her talents.

Duncan gave Vanna a strange look.

“Is it just my imagination, or did your mood suddenly get better?”

“Ah, I just thought about how I can keep hunting heretics. That made me a little happy.”

Duncan opened his mouth, but for a moment he did not know how to comment on this young inquisitor. Very soon, though, he turned his attention to something else.

He looked at the doll who was standing nearby, lost in thought.

“Morris and I have finished reporting our progress. It’s time to talk about what happened on your side.”

Chapter 336: Doll and spirit coffin

From the very beginning, the world in Alice's eyes had seemed completely different from that of an ordinary person. Yet no one had noticed this until today.

Not even Alice herself had realized it.

Duncan had heard from Vanna about the battle in the alley and about how Alice had acted in that fight. From the moment she sensed the hidden enemy through the "floating lines" to the moment she turned a fleeing Annihilator into a shattered porcelain doll, the whole thing had astonished Duncan.

Now all eyes were on Miss Doll, who had been confused from beginning to end.

"…So you really can't see the lines…" Alice finally reacted. She scratched her head, looking innocent. "I thought this was common sense. After all, that stuff is floating above everyone's heads and limbs…"

Duncan stared into Alice's eyes, his expression especially serious: "Let me confirm something. Everyone has these 'lines', right?"

"Yeah, everyone does, except you, Captain," Alice answered at once.

Duncan thought for a moment, then asked: "…Is it just my real body that doesn't have them, or this body I'm using now as well?"

"You don't have them in this body either," Alice answered honestly, then added: "And the body you had in Pland didn't have them either…"

Duncan nodded lightly. His thoughts raced, one guess after another rising and falling in his mind.

In Alice's eyes, lines floated on everyone in the world, yet not on him, and not even on the bodies he occupied. So these "lines" were not attached to flesh and blood. They must have symbolized something more essential. A soul? Or a personality?

When she was close enough, she could easily "grab" the lines on other people and use them to bind or attack her enemies. What was this ability? Was it something she had always possessed as Anomaly 099 but had never shown, or was it a mutation that appeared after she became one of the Vanished?

Duncan kept thinking, his gaze never leaving Alice's face. Even this slow-witted Doll finally felt awkward. Alice subconsciously twisted her neck and said: "Captain… you keep staring at me… I'm getting really nervous."

"Oh, sorry." Duncan came back to himself and blinked, easing the pressure in his gaze. Then he turned thoughtfully toward Vanna: "As far as I know, Alice's official designation has been changed to Anomaly 099-Doll, right?"

"Yes. Her original name was Doll spirit coffin." Vanna nodded at once. She had already guessed what Duncan meant. "You mean Alice's power is also related to this change?"

"Maybe. From the start, spirit coffin and Doll have represented different powers. The former is a symbol of death, so it has that simple, brutal decapitation ability, while the latter is the power to control humanoid husks. That fits the idea of a 'Doll'," Duncan said slowly. "Before, Alice was the 'contents' of the spirit coffin, so the combined form of Anomaly 099 showed only the traits of the spirit coffin. But now the Doll has become the main part of Anomaly 099, so her original ability has been released."

“spirit coffin and Doll each have different powers…” Morris, who had been silent at the side, muttered. “That is a very likely guess.”

Duncan felt a bit emotional inside.

He had always thought that the great power of Anomaly 099 had vanished. After Alice’s wooden box underwent the transformation, she had only been a somewhat eerie but merely animated and thinking cursed doll, weak, timid, and foolish to an extreme. He had never expected her to show such a strange ability today. He really did not know how to put it.

She really was worthy of a number within the first hundred, even if by the standards of the Vanished she was still very weak.

Alice clearly did not think that much. As Duncan and the others talked, her gaze kept shifting back and forth, looking at this person and that. It took her quite a while to barely understand part of what was going on. Then her face grew a little uneasy, and she carefully looked over: “…Captain, did I do something bad?”

“No, it was a good thing.” Duncan shook his head at once. “You were very brave, and you protected yourself well. cultists are never innocent.”

“Then…” Alice thought for a moment and lifted her hand, gesturing as she spoke. “Then is my ability a bad thing?”

Duncan looked quietly at the Doll. After a long moment, a faint smile suddenly appeared on his face: “It’s a good thing.”

Alice still did not quite understand.

“You can control it, right?” Duncan asked.

“Sure.” Alice waved her hand. “It’s very easy.”

“Then it’s a good thing,” Duncan said with a smile. “Having power is never bad. Losing control is the problem. Now you can help me even more,

Alice.”

Miss Doll finally smiled. She swayed from side to side with extra joy: “That’s great. Everyone suddenly looked so serious, I thought things were really bad…”

Duncan simply reached out and gently patted Alice’s hair.

She was swaying a bit too much; her head was almost about to fall off.

At the same time, his thoughts did not calm down.

Even though he now knew about Alice’s ability and had roughly guessed that Doll and spirit coffin each carried their own symbolism, that did not mean all the mysteries were solved. On the contrary, it only made him more aware that the Doll in front of him still hid many secrets.

He had spent quite some time with Alice. Because of those days together, he had grown used to this Doll making a fuss on the ship and to the way she ran back and forth in front of him all day while still seeming harmless. He had almost forgotten that, before becoming the cook among the Vanished, this Doll had first been Anomaly 099, a strange thing that rose from the cold Deep Sea after the death of the Frostholm queen.

In a sense, she and those eerie, twisted replicas actually shared the same origin.

But she was completely different from every other replica that had appeared so far. There was no way there was no reason behind that.

For some reason, he suddenly thought of something an Annihilator had said after the explosion of the Sea Swallow:

“If not for that queen…”

Duncan shook his head and pushed his tangled thoughts down for now. He looked up at Vanna.

“What happened tonight proves one thing. The replicas in the city really were the work of those Annihilators. And those cultists are not only acting in the shadows, they are also secretly watching the replicas they released into the city. That kind of observation looks a lot like they are collecting data.”

“From my experience, this is preparation for a bigger move. The replicas in the city are only the beginning, and the corruption on Dagger Island is probably another, larger testing ground.” Vanna nodded. “They also tried to transport the corruption from Dagger Island to Frostholm proper. Even though we stopped that operation, it already shows their plan has reached a very critical stage.”

“It doesn’t matter. I’ll step in, but first I need to know which gutter they’re hiding in,” Duncan said casually. “Killing a few cultists or priests, or even wiping out a few gathering places, is meaningless. The experience in Pland proved that.”

As he spoke, he raised his eyes. Through the gaps in his bandages, his gaze passed through the dirty window beside him and landed on the rows of spires and eaves of Frostholm.

“…Where are you hiding?”

The wind grew stronger. The second snowfall began. Snowflakes drifted down through the veil of night, and the distant streets turned hazy, as if they had sunk into fog.

The snow fell almost all night. Only when the Sun rose and the afterglow of the World’s Wound faded in the sunlight, when golden-red light spread along the streets into the city, did the falling snow slowly come to an end.

The cemetery’s heavy, solemn iron gate creaked open. The Old Caretaker, wrapped in a thick coat, hooked the latch that held the gate in place onto the

fence and glanced toward the street leading to the city.

Everything in sight was covered in deep snow. The distant streets had lost their shapes and edges under the thick white blanket, turning into a featureless expanse.

Steam pipes above the blocks spewed white mist. Heat from the steam cores was being sent to key nodes to melt the ice and snow on network hubs and power stations. Large snowplows rolled out too. These hulking machines, belching thick white smoke and roaring in a low rumble, drove along the streets to clear the main traffic routes.

Since the Visitor had left, the cemetery had returned to its quiet. No more anomalies disturbed the dead. But neither the cemetery's Warden nor the Guardians sent by the Church had relaxed after that.

In the second half of the night, an express dispatch had been sent to the Warden's hut through the high-pressure steam conduits. The express dispatch came from City Hall. Its content was strange: it ordered all supernatural defenders in the city to raise their alert level, but did not say what they were supposed to watch out for.

Not long after that, Agatha seemed to have received some information as well. She sent a squad to Hearth Street, and those Guardians still had not returned.

The wind and snow in the second half of the night had been fierce. The howling wind and swirling snowflakes had felt like a prophetic omen of something.

The Old Caretaker pulled his coat tighter.

"This damned weather…"

Chapter 337: Guest

The Old Caretaker did not like days when the snow kept falling. It was not only because the cold made his already overworked joints ache, but also because this kind of snowy day always reminded him of things from long ago.

Things that were not very good.

Like the rebellion fifty years ago. Like the great freeze thirty years ago. Like the huge collapse in the southern district seventeen years ago. When it snowed this hard, it was never a good sign.

The old man rubbed his hands together and looked back at the cemetery, which was also buried under snow.

Snow blurred the edges of the cemetery paths. On the white ground, only footprints traced the route to the morgue and the Warden’s hut. The gas lamps had gone out. The dark lamp posts stood in the snow like dead tree trunks, looking very lonely.

Several steam cars were parked on the open ground in the cemetery, already buried in snow. The black-clad Guardians were struggling to clear the snow off the cars and trying to open a path through the drifts wide enough for the vehicles to pass. They looked quite bedraggled.

They had to finish before the snow froze hard and the road became even harder to clear.

A gust of howling wind swept past. Gray smoke rushed in with it, and Agatha's figure stepped out of the wind and smoke. The young Gatekeeper came to stand beside the Old Caretaker and said: "Half the people will withdraw today. Only two squads will stay behind to help you ward the cemetery."

"They could all leave, for all I care. Then I could have some peace." The Old Caretaker lifted his eyelids and glanced at the Gatekeeper. "Keeping so many people here is a waste."

"It is not a waste of manpower. And you do not need to worry that I am short on people."

"I am not that free that I would worry about you," the Old Caretaker grumbled. Then, as if casually, he added: "You sent an elite squad out in the second half of the night. Did something happen in the city?"

Agatha looked at the old man: "You still care about things outside the cemetery?"

"I'm just asking. Say it or not, as you like." The Old Caretaker shrugged.

"…There was trouble on Hearth Street. A battle broke out between high-level supernatural individuals, and the disturbance was not small. The patrolling Guardians hurried there but arrived too late," Agatha said slowly. "Right now we can only be sure that one side in the fight were Annihilators. They died very miserably, and one of them died in a bizarre way that does not fit any supernatural power we know of."

The Old Caretaker's eyebrows clearly twitched, and his tone grew more serious: "Hearth Street?"

"…Don't worry. No innocent citizens were hurt," Agatha said. She seemed to know what he was worried about. "But from the squad's report, there is

more than one strange clue there. I may have to go there myself to see what is happening."

The Old Caretaker said nothing, only nodded lightly, but his eyes had already become serious.

Agatha was a young Gatekeeper, but even so, her title as Gatekeeper had been earned through strict training and harsh trials. As the Church's highest representative in the city-state, her actions alone showed how serious and urgent a situation was.

The situation on Hearth Street was probably not as calm and simple as her current tone made it sound. It was definitely more than a single supernatural fight. An elite Guardian squad had gone to investigate, and in the end the Gatekeeper herself had to go handle it. It was no small matter.

But that was something outside the cemetery, not something a retired Gravekeeper like him should pay attention to.

Let the young Gatekeeper and Guardians deal with it.

After quite a bit of effort, the Guardians finally cleared away the snow and started the steam cores of the cars. Two dark gray steam cars drove out of the cemetery and soon disappeared down the path toward the city blocks.

The Old Caretaker watched the two cars leave, shook his head, and got ready to go back into the cemetery.

But just as he was about to turn around, he caught sight of a small, familiar figure at the end of the path out of the corner of his eye.

A little girl in a thick coat was walking toward the cemetery with some effort.

The Old Caretaker stopped at once. He watched the little figure walk closer, his face looking a bit angry. The little figure also saw the old man standing

at the cemetery gate. She stopped by the roadside, lifted her face, and waved her arms happily, then kept trudging toward him, sinking deep with every step.

At last, she reached the tire tracks left by the two steam cars that had just departed, and her steps finally became a little easier. She bent down to pat the snow off the hem of her coat and the legs of her pants, then came to the cemetery gate and grinned up at the old man, whose face was stern and even a bit angry.

“Grandpa Caretaker, I’m here again!” Annie greeted the Old Caretaker happily.

Today she wore a thick white coat and matching white boots, with a white knit hat on her head. She almost seemed about to melt into the snow-covered city around her.

“You came out in this weather, and to a place like this!” The Old Caretaker glared, his tone very stern. “You’ll make your family worry.”

“I told my mother I’d be back soon today,” Annie said with a smile, her face red from the cold. “School is on break. I wanted to go play with my friends, but none of them wanted to go out, so I came to see you!”

“…Staying at home like your friends would still be better than running to the cemetery when the roads are buried in snow.” The old man’s tone was cold and hard. “The cemetery is closed today. There is too much snow inside. Go home.”

But the girl acted as if she had not heard. She only craned her neck to look past the old man, then lifted her face with hope: “My dad…”

“He didn’t come,” the old man said bluntly. “In weather this bad, even if there really were a burial planned, it would be postponed.”

Annie froze for a moment, but she did not look very disappointed. She pressed her lips together: “Then… I’ll come ask again when the weather is better… He will come someday, right?”

The Old Caretaker quietly gazed into the child’s eyes. For a brief second or two, he even felt a touch of regret, regret that six years ago he had made that promise to this child, that “your father will come back here”. In the end, his heart back then had still been a little too soft.

After a silence that felt very long, the old man finally spoke: “…Maybe, someday in the future, you will hear news of him.”

That was already as gentle as he could make it.

A twelve-year-old child should have understood those words by now.

Annie blinked and let a small smile appear on her face. Then she reached into the little bag she carried with her and took out a small package, which she handed to the old man.

“More biscuits?” The Old Caretaker raised his eyebrows.

“It’s ginger tea powder. I helped my mother make it, and we added herbs to drive out the cold and warm your stomach!” Annie said proudly. She stuffed the packet into his hand before he could refuse. “You are always guarding the cemetery all by yourself, and now it’s snowing again. It must be very cold at night, right?”

The old man looked at the thing in his hand.

He did not need it. The potion supplies that the Church gave the cemetery Warden were ten times more effective than this. His Warden’s hut, which looked so flimsy, was actually filled with protective runes and special materials. It could block far more than a bit of cold wind. Even if a runaway state really broke out in the cemetery, that little house could stand like a steel fortress and hold back the shock from outside.

“Thank you.” He accepted Annie’s gift. Maybe he had not smiled for too long, because the curve at the corner of his mouth looked a bit stiff. “This will be very useful to me.”

Then, right after that, his expression turned cold again.

“I’ve taken your gift. Now hurry home, and try not to go out these next few days.”

“Why?”

“…The city hasn’t been safe lately,” the Old Caretaker said seriously. He thought of what Agatha had just told him and of the supernatural incident on Hearth Street last night. “Go back and tell your mother to go out less in the near future. If anything feels wrong, ask the nearest Cathedral or Constable for help. Annie, this is very serious. Do you remember it?”

Annie seemed startled by the old man’s suddenly stern tone. She froze for a moment, then hurriedly nodded: “I… I remember.”

“Good. Then go home,” the old man said with a sigh, clearly dismissing her. “While it’s still…”

He lifted his head, and the second half of his sentence cut off.

Some time, a very tall, broad-shouldered figure had appeared near the cemetery gate and was now looking this way. The figure wore a long black coat and a wide-brimmed hat. Bandages wrapped the face, hiding every detail of the body under cloth and hat.

Beside that towering figure stood another person, a petite lady in a rich dark purple long dress. Her golden hair fell like a waterfall. She wore a soft hat, and a veil covered her face so her features could not be seen, yet she gave off an air of elegance and mystery.

But almost all of the Old Caretaker’s attention was on the tall, broad-shouldered figure. He stared in that direction, his eyes feeling as if some invisible force had pinned them in place. A faint noise began to thrum in his mind, and tiny shakes and distortions appeared at the edges of his vision. These were clear signs that his mind was being lightly corrupted and disturbed.

The experienced Old Caretaker realized at once what was happening. It was that “Visitor”.

Because he had met this unspeakable guest many times, and had once fallen into madness under the influence of incense, he had formed a certain link with the other party.

But this was only a shallow and almost harmless link, so the Old Caretaker did not lose the ability to act as badly as before.

He could still move. So he reached out and pulled Annie behind him.

“Child, don’t look over there.”

Chapter 338: What a Coincidence

Annie did not know what was happening—she had only just seen two strangers standing at the cemetery gate when the slightly hunched figure of the Old Caretaker blocked her view. The old man's somewhat tense voice reached her ears: "Child, don't look over there."

The young lady grew a little nervous: "Grandpa Caretaker, what's wrong?"

"Don't move, don't speak, it's fine." The old man spoke softly, his gaze still fixed on that burly figure. One of his hands hung at his side, blocking Annie's restless line of sight, while the other pressed against his chest—there he wore a charm amulet that, if necessary, could trigger the alarm for the whole cemetery.

The burly figure walked toward them.

All the old man's muscles tensed.

"Good morning." A deep voice came from beneath those thick bandages, like an echo from a tomb. "This should be my first formal visit."

He spoke in clear language and his manner was very friendly. Just like in their previous contact, this unspeakable Visitor showed a friendly stance.

But not a single muscle in the Old Caretaker's body dared to relax. He had thought before that this Visitor would come again sooner or later, and he had imagined what kind of situation it might be when they spoke. Yet he had never expected the other party to appear so openly at the cemetery gate, standing across from him and greeting him like this. He also did not know

whether Annie behind him would be affected by this Visitor, so he could only stand between them as much as he could and think quickly about how to respond.

The old man's tension was plain to Duncan.

He looked even more nervous than at their first meeting—was it because of the child he was shielding behind him?

"Relax a little," Duncan said, with a hint of amusement in his voice. "I have no hostility at all—and I certainly won't harm the child behind you."

"I know you are friendly, but your very existence can affect an ordinary person," the Old Caretaker said carefully, trying his best not to offend the Visitor before him. "This child has never received any supernatural training."

"Oh, then she is actually quite safe," Duncan said. "She can't see it. You should understand that as well."

The Old Caretaker fell silent for a moment. He understood what the other meant, and he knew that Annie, as an ordinary person, should not be affected by certain supernatural powers the way he was. But he still did not relax. He only asked carefully: "What are you here for this time?"

"That lady priest is not here?" Duncan glanced with some curiosity toward the cemetery. "I have some rather important matters to tell her."

"She just left," the Old Caretaker said, becoming even more cautious now that the other had mentioned Agatha. "What do you want with her?"

Then he paused and added: "I can reach her at any time. The cemetery's Warden is also clergy and can contact the Great Cathedral and the Gatekeeper directly."

“Ah, that is good. It saves me some trouble,” Duncan said as he raised his hand and reached into his pocket. The motion clearly made the cemetery’s Warden nervous, so Duncan shook his head with a small chuckle: “Don’t be nervous. If I truly meant harm, I would not need to raise my hand.”

As he spoke, he had already taken a sealed letter from the pocket of his coat and held it out to the old man.

“Pass this to the Gatekeeper named Agatha, or send it straight to your Great Cathedral,” Duncan said casually. “It is only a message. As long as the message is delivered, it will do.”

A… letter? It was actually a letter?!

The Old Caretaker stared in shock at what the other had taken out. He accepted it without thinking, then finally came back to himself. He blinked in confusion. He had never imagined that an unspeakable visitor would descend in the flesh upon the cemetery just to hand him a letter.

He turned the envelope over for another look.

On the back, he could see the mark and number of some small local printing shop—this was not any ritual secret letter formed by supernatural power. It had been bought at a newsstand on the corner, and might well have been picked up casually that very morning.

The old man raised his head. His slightly cloudy, yellowed eyes were full of doubt and questions.

“Just making a small contribution to the safety of the city-state,” Duncan said with a smile. Sadly, his friendly expression was hidden by his bandages. Then his gaze passed over the Old Caretaker and fell on the young lady hiding behind him. “Did I scare you?”

“No.” Annie shook her head, peeking carefully through the gaps between the old man’s fingers at that tall, burly figure across from her. “I am very

brave.”

“I have a niece. She is very brave too,” Duncan said, looking at the old man. “This child is…”

“She only wanted to visit the cemetery. She is an ordinary person who has nothing to do with the Church,” the old man said at once. Now that he realized Annie really had not been affected, he relaxed a little. “I was just trying to persuade this child to go back. The weather is dreadful today.”

“It is easy to slip on snowy days,” Duncan nodded. He looked at the little girl and asked casually: “What is your name? How old are you?”

The Old Caretaker’s heart tightened. He wanted to warn Annie, who had never come into contact with supernatural powers, not to speak. After all, giving one’s name to a high-ranking supernatural being of unknown origin was very dangerous—

But he was a step too late.

“My name is Annie,” the girl said without much caution. “Annie Barbelli, I am twelve years old!”

The gate of the cemetery suddenly fell silent.

Duncan quietly watched the young lady who was poking her head out from behind the Old Caretaker. His gaze fell on her eyes, and on the faint resemblance in her brows and features to Captain Cristo Barbelli.

He had only asked a casual question, yet he had not expected… such a coincidence.

The crunch of footsteps on snow came from the side. Alice looked in surprise at the young lady who had called herself “Annie Barbelli”, then turned her head toward Duncan: “Ah, I remember the surname Barbelli. Wasn’t that…”

Duncan slowly bent down until his gaze was level with the girl's. He tried to make his tone as gentle as possible: "Your surname is Barbelli?"

Perhaps because the mood had suddenly changed, Annie looked a little nervous. She shrank back behind the Old Caretaker: "Y-yes."

"What is your relationship with Captain Cristo Barbelli?"

"He is… my dad." Annie spoke in a low voice. Then she grabbed the Old Caretaker's clothes without thinking and looked up at him, as if seeking help.

But the old man did not react. He only looked stunned, as if something had occurred to him. With an expression of disbelief, he looked at Duncan, then looked in alarm and doubt at the young woman with the veil and golden hair falling over her shoulders.

"You are Captain Cristo's daughter—and you and your mother live on Hearth Street?" Duncan asked the young lady again.

Annie nodded in a hurry, then seemed to react: "You… know my dad?"

"…I have met him, though we are not very close," Duncan said softly. "He asked me to look in on you and your mother. I have not yet had time to visit you, and I did not expect to meet you here."

Annie's eyes widened in shock.

The Old Caretaker was just as surprised.

"My dad…" Annie opened her mouth but could not think what to say for a long time. After struggling for quite a while to find her words, she finally asked in a small voice: "He really is dead… right?"

Duncan nodded gently.

“Th-then… will he still be sent here?” Annie hurriedly asked again. “The lords say that those who believe in the God of Death will have their souls return to Bartok’s cemetery after they die, and then be led to that great gate. Grandpa Caretaker told me this cemetery is…”

As Annie spoke, her voice slowly grew quieter.

In truth, she had stopped believing those words the old man had told her long ago.

She was already twelve years old.

Duncan suddenly reached out and rubbed Annie’s head. A few unmelted snowflakes fell from her thick wool hat and mixed into the snow on the ground.

“Captain Cristo was an outstanding man, truly outstanding—he has already reached Bartok’s realm and is resting there now.”

Annie lifted her head and blinked.

She still did not really understand what Duncan’s words meant. She did not even understand what kind of being this tall, burly figure in front of her was.

But the cemetery’s Warden beside her reacted at once.

The old man suddenly pressed down on Annie’s shoulder to keep the child from speaking further. Then he raised his head and met Duncan’s gaze: “What you said… is that really what happened?”

“…I believe so,” Duncan said after thinking for a moment. He did not truly know what that so-called gate of the Death God Bartok was, nor did he know exactly what humans experienced after death. But in front of a child, he knew what he should say—and it was also what he sincerely hoped was true. “I personally saw him off.”

The Old Caretaker’s pupils shrank slightly, but he quickly hid the change in his expression.

“I should be going as well,” Duncan said. He glanced at Annie, who still did not quite understand what was happening, then looked at the cemetery’s Warden. “I still have many things I would like to say, but there is much I must do. We can meet again when there is a chance.

“Also, do not forget that letter.”

The Old Caretaker blinked. Before he could speak, the eerie green flame before his eyes flared once and vanished.

Chapter 339: Agatha's Investigation

The Visitor left as suddenly as he had arrived.

The cemetery's Old Caretaker stood there in a daze. He stared at the place where the flame had faded, his mind still full of all the information the other had revealed in their brief conversation. Only when Annie tugged at his sleeve beside him did the old man suddenly come back to himself.

He lowered his head and saw Annie looking at him uneasily. In the girl's eyes there was not only helplessness, but also tension and confusion.

Perhaps she already understood what it meant to part from someone forever, but she could not yet fully understand what had just happened.

The Old Caretaker bent down, his aged, stiff joints aching slightly in the winter cold. He reached out and brushed the snow from Annie's shoulder as he said: "Annie, do not be afraid. Nothing bad has happened."

"Grandpa Caretaker…" The girl's lips moved as she tried to find words, but she did not know where to begin. "That person just now…"

"Do not ask too much and do not think too much. Just like the textbooks say, do not pry into knowledge that is not open to mortals—you only need to know that that was a Visitor. He bore you no ill will. Now He has left, and any connection between you and Him ends here."

"Then my dad…"

“Your father may have done something very great—beyond anything any of us can imagine,” the Old Caretaker said softly, placing his hand gently on the girl’s hair. “Annie, do not worry anymore. He no longer drifts on the sea. He has gone to a better place. Go back and tell your mother. She has been waiting for this news for a long time.”

Annie pressed her lips together. After hesitating for a long time, she asked quietly: “This time… it is real?”

“It is real,” the Old Caretaker said with a smile. “You are no longer a six-year-old child.”

Annie nodded, half understanding, then said goodbye to the cemetery’s Old Caretaker. She turned and walked toward the little path that led back to the streets, following the ruts in the road that had not yet frozen into ice. She walked slowly in the direction of home, slowly blending into the silver-white backdrop of the city.

At the cemetery gate, the Old Caretaker watched the path for a long time. Only when Annie’s figure vanished at the corner did he let out a soft breath.

The child had not slipped and fallen this time.

Then he raised his hand and pressed lightly against the item in his pocket. A letter that seemed to hold countless secrets lay there in silence.

A letter from an unspeakable visitor. Even material that looked ordinary might carry unimaginable knowledge and mysteries. What did this letter really mean?

The Old Caretaker’s expression grew serious. He turned and went back into the cemetery, waving a hand behind him. The heavy iron gate creaked shut.

The cemetery would not open again today.

…

Agatha looked sternly at the scattered fragments on the ground. The cold wind that kept blowing from the mouth of the alley stirred her long hair and seeped through the gaps in her clothing and bandages. In that bone-chilling air, it felt as if the terror and despair of the two Annihilators at the moment of death still hung, frozen.

Several black-clad Guardians were working nearby. The team that had first come to deal with the scene had already sealed off both ends of the alley, and people were investigating clues in the nearby lanes as well. The evidence work went on in an orderly way, but the confusion in Agatha's heart had not eased.

What kind of power could shatter a person into pieces like a porcelain doll?

So far, there was no known divine magic or heretic spell that could cause such an effect. Even the many kinds of spells used by Abyssal demons did not produce anything this strange.

The young Gatekeeper lifted her Gatekeeper's cane and nudged one of the fragments with its tin tip. The pale shard, like a piece of porcelain, turned over on the ground with a crisp sound.

It flipped over, showing about half a face, including the lips, the bridge of the nose, and one eye.

Even broken as it was, it clearly held the cultist's look of terror in his final moment.

And… a faint, eerie smile?

Agatha frowned. She could see that the lips on that porcelain fragment curved in a suspicious way, as if a calm, peaceful smile had just begun to appear and then been frozen in place. That tiny curve, together with the terror filling the single eye, made the face even more uncanny and disturbing.

After thinking for a moment, she shook her head and walked deeper into the alley, toward another “scene.”

A heap of remains, almost burned to charcoal, lay piled up in the alley. Around the remains she could see traces of fierce fighting and explosions. The area of damage was large, but the battle itself had clearly been one-sided—and the style of fighting was completely different from that pile of fragments at the mouth of the alley.

One of the priests examining the scene straightened up from beside the remains, took off his gloves, and nodded to Agatha: “An Annihilation Priest who has completed deep purification. Judging from the degree of flesh distortion, his strength was not low. In theory, even if he ran into a full twelve-person Guardian squad, he might still be able to kill his way out. Yet he was taken down quickly—and we can hardly see any trace of a counterattack.”

Agatha frowned slightly: “Can you tell what kind of opponent he faced?”

The priest shook his head: “The simplest and most brutal kind of attack—pure physical force. That actually makes it hard to judge the other side’s identity. But we did find some traces of water-vapor anomalies condensing nearby. That may be our only clue.”

“Condensed water vapor… only that little trace?” Agatha said softly. She glanced back toward the mouth of the alley. “Two completely different styles of fighting.”

“Yes. One is simple and brutal, the other eerie and dangerous. What they have in common is that both are very powerful—the heretics at priest level had no chance to fight back at all,” the priest said with a nod. “The only good news is that they are clearly enemies of the Cult of Annihilation.”

“The enemy of our enemy is not necessarily our friend,” Agatha said, shaking her head. “Besides, they clearly prefer to act from the shadows—they do not want to show themselves. That alone is reason enough to be wary.”

She paused, then asked: “What about the investigation of the nearby residents?”

“The nearby residents heard the sounds of battle, but most did not dare to peek. From what they say, we can only estimate the time and how long it lasted—it happened sometime after one in the morning and may have lasted less than three minutes.”

“That is all? Nothing else?”

“We have no more information for now,” the priest said, spreading his hands. “I have already sent people to go door to door, including the alleys further away, to see if we can find any reports of strangers. But Hearth Street is a very large district. I doubt we will get results in a short time.”

Just then, a set of hurried footsteps sounded from nearby and cut off the conversation between Agatha and the priest.

A Guardian with short brown hair hurried into the alley and came to the priest’s side to report.

“Inside a building?” The priest frowned at once as he listened to his subordinate’s report, then looked up at the house standing diagonally across from the alley.

Seeing this, Agatha asked at once: “What is it?”

“We found something in house number forty-two,” the priest said at once. “There is a Senkin woman inside who was attacked by an supernatural power and fell into a deep sleep. And on the second floor of the house, we found a room corrupted by something uncanny.”

…

At Cemetery No. 3, inside the Warden’s little house, the Old Caretaker carefully locked the door, then walked to the writing desk in the corner with a serious expression.

He had already instructed the Guardians outside to keep watch around the hut and lay down plenty of protections in the open ground around it—but that still was not enough.

After reaching the desk, he took incense, essential oils, candles, and powdered herbs from the drawers and began to arrange a powerful altar.

He lit the candles in their appointed places and added essential oil and herb powder to them. Then, with the breath of incense, he blessed the whole desk. He set the censer in the middle of the candlesticks and built the altar according to its symbolic pattern. He carried out all this work with practiced ease, every motion as if rehearsed hundreds of times.

This was the skill a veteran should have.

A few minutes later, the altar was complete.

The Old Caretaker let out a quiet breath. He looked at the pale flames burning on the candlesticks and at the thin incense smoke, almost solid, gathering above the desk. He could feel the power of the God of Death Bartok briefly descend upon the little house. The strength of divine blessing lingered around the desk, stabilizing the order of space and time here and holding his own mind steady.

When dealing with unspeakable knowledge, no amount of careful and complex preparation could be too much.

He slowly sat down and finished a benediction in his heart. Only then did he solemnly take the letter from his pocket.

The old man examined the envelope.

This was what that unspeakable Visitor had given him. The Visitor had told him to pass it on to Gatekeeper Agatha, but had also said that it was enough if the message reached the Great Cathedral in Frostholm. In all that, he had never said that others were forbidden to open the letter.

If all that mattered was sending the message, then he could read it first and then convey it.

After all, the cemetery's Warden was the first line of defense on the way to the Great Cathedral.

The old man let out a gentle breath. Once he felt fully prepared, he picked up the letter opener at his side and carefully slit open the seemingly ordinary envelope.

A folded sheet of paper slid out of the envelope.

With an expression more solemn than ever and a resolve almost like martyrdom, the Old Caretaker slowly unfolded the paper—

The words "denunciation letter" leapt into view.

The Old Caretaker: "…?"

Chapter 340: Sinking into the Spirit Realm

The Warden’s cottage grew quiet. A strange stillness seemed to solidify in the air. The Old Caretaker even had an illusion. He felt as if even the altar set up on the desk – the candle flames, the incense smoke, and the faint Spiritual Insight power in the air – had all paused for a moment.

Was it an illusion?

The old man lifted his head in confusion. He saw the flames on the candlestick flickering, but it was as if they had only started to move at the moment he looked up.

He stared at the pale flames for a long time. Then he slowly shook his head and lowered his gaze back to the letter in front of him. He read the words with a strange feeling he had never had in his life.

But after only a few lines, he no longer cared about that sense of wrongness and embarrassment. The contents of the letter were making him realize how serious the situation was.

There was a warning that the city-state was being infiltrated by the power of The Deep Sea, evidence of large-scale activity by Annihilators, a guess that the lord of the Abyssal Deep had invaded the Mortal Realm, and… a warning about Dagger Island.

The Old Caretaker stared fixedly at the lines of text in his hand. Suddenly he felt that the uneasy mood spreading through the city-state at last had an

explanation.

He did not know whether he should trust this “report” from some unnameable being, but one thing was beyond doubt – he had to inform the Gatekeeper at once, and inform the Cathedral.

…

Agatha bent down and carefully examined the Senkin lady who lay asleep on the sofa. The woman still slept soundly, completely unaware that a crowd of Guardians had gathered in the room. From time to time she even let out faint, uneasy murmurs in her sleep.

She could still talk in her sleep. That meant her mind had not been damaged in the “attack”, and the uninvited guests who had entered the house earlier had not meant her harm.

Agatha let her gaze sweep over Galina. This Senkin miss had a body that could almost be called hulking. Most Senkin were like this. They were born with powerful bodies and skin as tough as stone. After a simple check, the young Gatekeeper saw that the muscles on Galina’s body tightened now and then. Together with the uneasy mutterings she had heard a moment ago, it seemed this Senkin lady was not having a peaceful dream.

A priest in a gray-white coat stood nearby and reported to Agatha: “No external wounds, no signs of mental corruption, and no traces of a fight. On the surface it looked like normal sleep – but she could not be woken. Considering there is no damage to the locks and the kitchen shows signs of recent use, our first judgment is that the ‘intruders’ were invited into the house.”

“…They might be acquaintances, or guests who had gained her trust,” Agatha murmured. “What about the situation on the second floor?”

The priest nodded and said: “We have already collected many samples. We also found a Final Record. The person who left it should be the source of those… anomalous substances in the room. Based on other clues we found in the house, the one who left the record should be named ‘Brown Scott’. He was a folklorist.”

“A folklorist?” Agatha frowned. “Have you checked his background?”

“We have already sent people to the nearest Resident registry to pull his file, but we have not heard back yet.”

“Stay here and watch over this lady first,” Agatha nodded. “I will go upstairs and take a look.”

“Yes, Lady Gatekeeper.”

On the second-floor study, the Guardians had already finished the first round of recording the scene and gathering samples. When Agatha arrived, her subordinates were trying to clear away the dried “mud” hanging from the shelves so they could move the many books in the room.

In places where an supernatural runaway state had occurred, any books left at the scene were very likely to be corrupted by supernatural power. Moving these books away and sealing them for later study was a necessary part of procedure, even if doing so might “damage the scene”.

Agatha’s gaze fell on the dried gray-black sludge.

These things… reminded her of the samples they had collected in Cemetery No. 3, those strange substances that seemed to be elements.

She also saw the Final Record the priest had mentioned earlier. It lay in the most eye-catching place on the desk.

At first glance, Agatha judged that this manuscript had already been handled. Its surface showed clear traces of cleaning, and the work had been

done very carefully.

This was not something ill-intentioned intruders would do. It was more like the work of a “professional” who, like her, had come to investigate for a proper reason. Thinking of the lady sleeping on the first floor, Agatha already had some early guesses in her mind.

A mysterious third party who at least did not seem to be an enemy. Were they the same people who had fought the Annihilators in the alley outside?

If so… then this third party’s power deserved close attention.

As all kinds of guesses and deductions spun in her mind, Agatha slowly let her gaze move over the lines of the Final Record. As those words, soaked with resolve, courage, and awareness, came into view, the Gatekeeper’s eyes grew heavy and solemn.

The Master who had left this record had actually kept clear consciousness and memory.

After a short silence, Agatha took a light breath. She carefully set the Final Record back on the desk, then lifted her Gatekeeper’s cane with one hand and slowly drew its tin tip across the floor.

The sound of metal scraping on planks rang out. Pale flame burned at the cane’s tip and left the same pale glowing marks on the floor. As the flame and glowing trail spread, the sound of the Gatekeeper’s cane against the floor began to change. It grew low and slow, as if a thick barrier was forming in the air, bit by bit sealing off the space around her.

Soon Agatha had outlined a triangle large enough for an adult to stand in. Inside the triangle she drew the rune of the God of Death Bartok. Then she stepped into the center of the triangle, set the Gatekeeper’s cane at her side with one hand, and reached toward her own eye socket with the other.

A fresh, living eyeball popped out of her eye socket and fell into her palm.

In an instant, the area around her grew quiet. All sounds from the Mortal Realm were shut out beyond the triangle by an invisible barrier. Then, in the silence, countless whispers rose up, as if hundreds of unseen watchers were crowding around the triangle and chattering endlessly at the Gatekeeper.

Agatha lifted her hand, palm up, and used her own eyeball to scan the surroundings.

Everything in the room, including the busy Guardians, the dust motes drifting in the air, and the hands of the Chronometer Clock on the wall, froze like amber. As they froze, their colors quickly faded and sank into gloom. A strange pale glow spread in from outside the window, shone through the boards nailed over it, and cast a wavering light over the room.

In this eerie, pale, motionless space, only Agatha in the center of the triangle still kept the appearance and colors of a living person. Her eyelids stayed shut as she held up her eyeball in her left hand, sweeping it around while she spoke calmly: “I wish to speak with the dead here.”

The countless irritating whispers around her suddenly grew much weaker. Agatha turned her left hand to make her eyeball look toward the desk not far away.

That was where the folklore scholar Brown Scott had last worked while leaving the Final Record. In theory, if a soul had truly lingered here, some trace of its afterglow should still be wandering in that place.

Even though the “mud” all over the room showed that what had once been here was very likely just a “Monster” condensed out of supernatural power, that Monster had clearly held some kind of humanity inside. On that point, after reading the record, Agatha was sure.

Yet beside that empty desk, she found nothing.

There was no afterglow of a soul, no projection shaped by lingering thoughts, not even a tiny glimmer that might mean leftover Spiritual Insight. There was only a colorless desk with black matter piled on it, and fine wisps of smoke rising from the matter.

Agatha's eyeball slowly swayed in her palm.

The Gatekeeper was thinking.

Was it because too much time had passed since death and the soul's afterglow had already faded? Or because the thing that had stayed in this room had only been a replica, and so had no real humanity, only imitated memories and a false personality? Or… had that soul already passed through Bartok's gate and entered the place of rest?

The last guess seemed especially impossible. From the state of the room, even if Brown Scott's soul had once stayed here, it had already suffered severe corruption. And a corrupted soul could not pass through that gate.

So where had the soul gone?

The low whispers around her rose again, even louder and more annoying than before.

The Shadows of the Spirit Realm were growing restless. They did not like this sudden intruder. Even for a powerful Gatekeeper, it was best not to stay at this depth for too long.

Thinking this, Agatha raised her Gatekeeper's cane and struck it twice on the floor.

The tin Gatekeeper's cane made a thunder-like boom when it hit the floor.

"Agatha, Gatekeeper of the mortal world, wishes to speak with the Gatekeeper of the world of the dead."

Chapter 341: Threefold Questioning

The Gatekeeper’s words carried great power. With the thunderous echo of the tin Gatekeeper’s cane striking the floor, her voice spread in layers through this strange, chaotic depth of the Spirit Realm.

In a moment, the unseen Whisperers in the room fell silent again. The whole world sank into a brief stillness. Only a few seconds later, a deep rumbling sound came from far away, as if a huge body were walking toward her with heavy steps.

Agatha raised her hand and turned her eyeball to face the direction of the sound. There, in her line of sight, was the window nailed over with layers of boards. Pale light shone in the cracks of the window. Suddenly all the light trembled and then dimmed, as if something huge had come to stand before the window.

The next second, the crisscrossing boards shattered without a sound. Countless gray-black splinters flew out silently, then stopped in midair near the window, as if frozen in amber. A giant appeared outside the window.

The giant wore a black robe that stood for death. The body under the robe was wrapped in bandages. Only the eyes in his head gave off a dim yellow glow. He stood outside the building, his size almost equal to the whole house. Then the giant bent down slightly so that his head was level with the second-floor window. He turned his head. No expression could be seen on

the face covered by bandages. Then he raised his hand and held out three fingers to Agatha.

“Threefold Questioning.” The giant’s voice sounded like thunder.

Agatha froze for a moment when she saw this giant.

This was not the Gatekeeper she knew. The Gatekeeper she usually spoke with did not have such a huge body. The one before her was clearly a higher Envoy. Why would this Envoy answer her call?

But she soon pushed down her doubt. All the goings and comings of the Envoys followed the will of the God of Death Bartok. There was no need for her to dig into this. The most important thing now was to find out what had happened here.

“I am looking for the soul that last lingered in this house,” she said, pointing with her Gatekeeper’s cane at the empty desk not far away. “He may have been corrupted, but now his whereabouts are unknown.”

“That soul has left. He has already entered the realm of rest. A great power has erased his debts. corruption is no longer a problem.”

The death Envoy outside spoke in a thunderous voice, then folded down one finger. Two questions remained.

Agatha paused and at once caught the word “great power” in the Envoy’s answer. She quickly weighed her thoughts and asked her second question: “Where did that great power come from? Who erased that soul’s debts?”

“The Flame Usurper.” The Envoy’s eyes, murky and yellow, seemed to flicker. When he spoke this term, there was a clear tone of warning. Then he folded down another finger.

As Agatha heard the words “Flame Usurper”, a wave of dizziness hit her. At once she realized that she was touching some kind of “knowledge” from the

deep layers of the world, something never revealed to the mortal side.

But she did not lose her composure. When one spoke with the Gatekeeper on the other side, it was normal to brush against dangerous knowledge now and then. She might be young, but she had experience in this. Since the Envoy outside chose to tell her this word, it meant the term was at least within what she could bear.

If it had truly been a taboo-level question, the Envoy would have warned her.

Agatha steadied herself and took a light breath, then asked her third question: “Who is the Flame Usurper?”

“Humans.”

The Envoy outside said this, then folded down his last finger. His figure vanished in a roaring gust of wind, giving Agatha no chance to speak further.

The wooden splinters that had been scattered and frozen in the air suddenly flew again and in a flash rejoined into their original shape. The window was sealed once more. The hazy pale light spilled through the cracks and fell on the slightly stunned Agatha.

The young Gatekeeper stood there in a daze. For the first time in her life, after speaking with the Gatekeeper on the other side, she felt at a loss. The answer to her last question still hovered clearly in her mind, but she had no idea what that strange answer meant at all.

Humans? What kind of answer was that? Did it mean the Flame Usurper was a human? That a power the death Envoy called “great power” came from a human?

What kind of “human” would that be?! Was that still a “human” at all?!

The noisy sounds rose again. In the air beyond the triangle, countless unseen watchers seemed to be stirring. The noise broke off Agatha's thoughts. The eyeball in her palm turned, and she saw strands of pitch-black matter like hair spreading outside the triangle, growing thicker like ink dropped into water.

The Spirit Realm had begun to push this unwelcome guest out.

She shook her head and lifted her hand to put the eyeball back into its socket. At the same time she picked up the Gatekeeper's cane and gave it a gentle sweep, scattering the pale flame that traced the triangle on the floor.

In an instant, the Spirit Realm faded. Sound returned. Color and light filled her vision again. She was back at the busy scene with the Guardians, and her subordinates were still working around her in tense, orderly fashion.

Agatha rolled her eye a little, then reached into her coat pocket and took out a small bottle. She pinched open the cap, tipped back her head, and dropped two drops of eye medicine into her eye socket.

The dry, uncomfortable feeling quickly faded.

A subordinate came over. He waited until Agatha put away the bottle before stepping forward to ask: "Did you find any clues?"

"The soul has already left. The Gatekeeper on the other side confirmed that it passed through Bartok's gate and entered the place of rest," Agatha said calmly. "…That is all. There are no more clues."

For safety's sake, she did not mention the term "Flame Usurper" to the subordinate.

This word clearly held power and even pointed straight at extremely dangerous deep layers knowledge. She did not know what might happen if she spoke it aloud. It would be better to go back and study the texts carefully first.

The subordinate clearly noticed that Agatha was hiding something. But as an experienced Guardian, he asked nothing, just nodded and went back to his work.

Just then, footsteps sounded in the corridor outside, interrupting Agatha's thoughts.

A Guardian in charge of watching over the downstairs came in and said: "Lady Gatekeeper, that lady has woken up."

The young Senkin had woken up?

Agatha at once put her thoughts aside and quickly went downstairs, where she saw Galina, now awake from her sleep.

The strong lady with stone-like skin sat on the sofa, holding a cup of calming herbal tea the priest had mixed by hand. Her eyes looked a little blank as she stared at the table in front of her. Only when Agatha sat down across from her and lightly tapped the table did she slowly react.

The young Gatekeeper said: "Hello, my name is Agatha. You should know me." At the same time she carefully watched the state of the person across from her. "Do you know what happened?"

The apprentice holding the herbal tea spoke a little slowly: "I… my name is Galina." Her eyes were still a bit unfocused, as if she had not fully shaken off her sleep. "Sorry, Lady Gatekeeper, my head is still a mess. I feel like I had a very, very long dream. In the dream I kept doing math problems without stopping, proving them again and again. All the studying I did growing up put together was never this tiring…"

"Doing math problems?" Agatha paused, then asked with a thoughtful look: "Do you remember how you fell asleep? Before you fell asleep, did you receive anyone, or do anything in particular?"

Galina frowned slightly and seemed to be trying hard to recall. But after a full half minute she still shook her head in apology: “Sorry, I don’t remember. I don’t even remember anything from yesterday afternoon until now. If these Guardians hadn’t told me, I wouldn’t even know… that something happened at home.”

Agatha frowned deeply.

Memory being covered, deep layers sleep, and “doing math problems” – this sounded rather like the power used by the Clergy of the God of Wisdom.

But the God of Wisdom was also one of the four True Gods. Why would that God’s priests do such a thing?

They were not heretics.

There were simply too many things today to feel confused about.

Agatha rubbed her temple, a little headache creeping in.

All sorts of tangled lines knotted together in her mind.

The strange and suspicious battle marks in the alley outside, the recent cultist activity in the city-state, the elements and the suspicious accidents in the mines, the weird events in this house, the message brought by the death Envoy…

Galina looked at the Gatekeeper in front of her with some nervousness and said: “Excuse me…” Although Agatha looked very young, she was still the highest-level Church Herald in the city-state, and Galina could not help feeling uneasy. “My teacher, is he all right?”

“Your teacher?” Agatha looked a little puzzled.

“He should be upstairs. His name is Brown Scott,” Galina explained quickly. “I was a bit confused when I woke up and forgot to say. He needs

quiet…”

Agatha froze at once.

Chapter 342: Morris’s Trick for Getting Approved

When Duncan and Alice went to the cemetery together, Morris and Vanna were not idle either. Early in the morning, they went to the citizen Help Center in the southern part of the Upper City to carry out something Duncan had asked them to do.

They had to find a stable and legal place to stay in the city-state of Frostholm and, if possible, one or two identities they could use openly.

After all, they might be active in this city-state for a long time. They could not live like cultists, hiding and running every day.

Since the informants Tyrian had left in the city were no longer reliable, Morris decided to figure out a solution himself.

Frostholm’s citizen Help Center was a huge domed building. Two long side wings stretched out from the main body. It was called a citizen Help Center, but in truth the building also received visitors entering the city-state and handled a huge amount of third?party agency work. Almost everything could be done here, from registering house rentals and sales, to issuing temporary passes, to hiring short-term maids, gardeners, and laundry workers. The long side wings were packed with all kinds of registration windows and offices, and the giant domed hall was always noisy and crowded. In this, it was very different from Pland.

As soon as they stepped into the great dome, a wave of heat hit them. Frostholm’s special high?pressure heating system drove away the winter

chill, and bright electric lights hung high under the dome, lighting the whole building.

The place had only been open for a short while, but many people had already poured in. citizens looking for short?term work or registering property rentals and sales moved between countless windows and counters. The roar of voices mixed with the constant “click” and “hiss” from air? driven tube lines starting up again and again. Vanna clearly was not used to this kind of environment. She carefully avoided the streams of people around her and muttered softly to Morris: “In Pland, you don’t put job counters and housing counters in the same building.”

“You have to think about the cost of heating big buildings, and how long it takes to refit a heat?pump exchange station,” Morris shook his head and said, “Most of this city’s basic public facilities were left over from Frostholm’s Queen era. But that glorious age is over. After the Great Uprising, Frostholm barely recovered seventy or eighty percent of its strength with the Boiling Gold industry. Starting from scratch to replace all the underground pipe systems and steam?power networks the Queen left behind is not a simple job.”

“So they just keep making do like this?” Vanna’s eyes went wide. “These are half?century?old antiques!”

“What else can they do?” Morris sighed. “On one side there is the city’s decline. On the other side there is population pressure. Then there was the collapse of the sea cliffs back then, which cut down the livable area. Facilities from fifty years ago may be a bit cramped by now, but they barely still work. Since they still work, they keep using them. This isn’t only Frostholm’s problem. Many old industrial city?states are like this. Lively cities like Pland are the minority.”

Vanna fell silent.

This was not a field she was good at thinking about.

While they talked, Morris had already found the location of the migrant registration counter on the dizzying map of lines above the hall. He and the tall Vanna threaded their way through the crowd and finally reached a relatively quiet counter.

A long wooden counter stood against the wall, divided into several sections by iron bars. Behind each section sat a clerk in a gray?blue uniform. Their faces were as stiff as the iron bars beside them, and it was clear they planned to keep that expression until the end of the workday.

“We need a residence permit, and we also want to find a short?term rental,” Morris said as he came to one of the sections. He sat down on a squeaky iron chair and spoke to the sallow?faced middle?aged man inside: “We landed today.”

“Which pier?” The middle?aged clerk with the sallow face lifted his eyelids and glanced at the old man opposite him. When he noticed that a one? meter?ninety lady was standing behind the old man, he froze for a second, but he quickly went back to an official tone: “Show me the pier certificate and your tickets.”

Vanna frowned and looked down at Morris.

Morris’s face stayed calm. He spread his hands and said: “We lost them. Maybe we dropped them when we left the pier, and that ship has already left.”

The clerk in the section stopped what he was doing at once. He looked up, his poker face tinged with displeasure: “That won’t do. We must have the certificate. Go back to the pier and get it reissued.”

“But I have something else,” Morris said. As he spoke, he reached into his coat and took out a folded document and a small booklet with a dark red

cover, which he passed over. “They should work as legal identification.”

The clerk waved his hand on reflex: “No pier certificate, no deal. Nothing else can—”

He saw the mark on the small booklet and stopped talking. Then he reached out, opened the folded document, and ran his eyes over it.

His poker?face expression changed at once.

“An academic transit pass issued by the Truth Academy and the Boundless Sea Navigation Council,” Morris said, “allowing the holder to stay and visit in all city?states under the protection of the True Gods. During the stay, the local city?state university under the Truth Academy serves as the guarantor.” He then pointed at the red booklet. “This is my credential. A dual certificate in degree and theology from the Truth Academy. My rank is Professor.”

The sallow?faced middle?aged clerk stared in a daze for a moment, then slowly lifted his head, looking a little lost: “Uh… good morning, Professor Morris… It’s a pleasure to meet you. Of course your identity is legal…”

Relief showed on Morris’s face.

But the clerk paused again. He seemed to struggle with himself for a moment, then stiffened up and said: “But… I still need to know which ship you came on. That’s… the rule.”

Morris’s newly relaxed expression turned a bit awkward. Next to him, Vanna rubbed the bridge of her nose and quietly turned her head away.

Morris sighed and looked at the middle?aged clerk in front of him, who was clearly nervous yet still staring straight at him.

“You already know which ship I came on,” he said with a sigh. A faint light flickered in his eyes. “Issue the certificate.”

The clerk froze. His eyes seemed to go blank for a second. Then he lowered his head and started working the clicking Punch?Card Machine. He fed the punched card into the pneumatic tube line container beside the counter.

A moment later, along with hisses and clicks from inside the pipes, a card returned from some approval office deep in the building and dropped back into the counter unit.

The clerk slid the punched card into a small reader, checked the receipt number and anti?forgery code, and then finally began to fill out the contents of the certificate form. Without raising his head, he said: “All I can do here is issue this certificate. You need to take it to the west wing, to window A?12. They should have short?term rentals that match your request there.”

“Thank you,” Morris said as he took the finished document. He paused, then added quietly: “I’m sorry.”

With that, he and Vanna hurried away from the counter and walked toward the next window.

“This is the first time I’ve done something like that,” after they had walked a short distance, the old gentleman lowered his voice and said, “I really wanted to handle it through normal paperwork…”

“We came here on a ghost ship that has no place in this world. You know normal procedures will never solve that problem,” Vanna also spoke softly. There seemed to be a bit of laughter in her tone. “Desperate times, desperate measures.”

“…What do you think the odds are that Mr. Duncan gets a legal ship registration certificate for the Vanished?” Morris asked.

“What do you think?” Vanna replied.

“…All right,” Morris sighed and looked at the certificate in his hand. “Let’s just hope Heidi never finds out about this. Next time we run into something

like this, I’d rather forge a fake ticket first.”

Vanna watched the sighing Morris with a half?smile. Ever since she was little, this was the first time she had seen such a troubled look on the face of this old scholar, who was always known for being “rigorous in study and strict with the rules.” It actually seemed… quite interesting.

At the same time, Agatha had just finished a field investigation and had not yet made it back to the great Cathedral when she received an urgent report from a subordinate, sent from Cemetery No. 3.

Sitting in the steam car, Agatha looked at the letter that had just been handed to her. Her eyes slowly went blank.

It was a denunciation letter—from that indescribable visitor.

She had just left, and right after that, this letter had been delivered to the cemetery.

Should she sigh over this near miss, or over that visitor’s strange behavior?

She put away the letter, her mind racing.

Unease spread in her heart. One matter suddenly felt urgent.

“Turn. Go to East Harbor.”

The subordinate driving in front was a bit surprised and asked: “We’re not going back to the Cathedral first?”

“Plans have changed. East Harbor first,” Agatha said firmly. “I have a bad feeling… Something may be trying to land while it has the chance.”

The driver was completely confused, but the habit of obeying orders made him press down his doubts at once.

At the next intersection, the black steam car slowed and turned, then sped toward the Harbor district in the eastern part of the city?state.

Chapter 343: Return

In the military administration zone of the Harbor in eastern Frostholm, many people had not slept all night.

It had been more than twenty?four hours since the Sea Swallow lost contact. Even when the Harbor Cathedral sent an Aetheric Call to the priest aboard the Sea Swallow, there was no reply.

All the clues and traces pointed toward a bad outcome.

Inside the harbor office, a middle?aged man in a Frostholm navy commander’s uniform sat behind his desk with a dark face. A few other commanders sat on chairs around the room. The room was not very big, and the air inside was heavy and oppressive, as if it were brewing a storm.

“We still haven’t found any trace of the Sea Swallow. We searched three times from the point of its last signal back toward Frostholm’s main island. There was nothing on the sea,” said a civilian officer with short light?brown hair, shaking his head.

“The most optimistic guess is that the Sea Swallow’s communications system failed and something happened to the ship’s priest, so the ship went into a runaway state and drifted off the route. But honestly, that’s way too optimistic,” another officer sighed. “A ship that size, even in a runaway state, couldn’t drift out of the search area in such a short time. The more likely case is that the Sea Swallow had a serious accident and already sank. A coastal patrol boat reported hearing faint explosions and seeing distant flashes in the night. That may have been the Sea Swallow.”

“A ship that big would still take hours to sink, right? We sent out search teams as soon as the Sea Swallow lost contact,” the civilian officer with light?brown hair frowned. “And there was that corruption?tainted fuel slick on the sea. How could all those traces vanish so cleanly? What, did the whole ship just drop straight to the bottom in an instant?”

“…We should send people to Dagger Island to confirm the situation,” another female officer said. “Maybe the Sea Swallow never sailed toward Frostholm’s main island. Maybe it got stuck near Dagger Island for some reason…”

“Dagger Island is in a special state right now. Sending people ashore takes a lot of paperwork…”

“Then just try to make contact. That paperwork is simpler. The governor’s office can sign off in half an hour at best…”

The discussion in the room went on and on, until a calm voice from behind the desk cut everyone off: “Protocol Twenty?Two.”

The room fell silent at once. The officers who had been talking lifted their eyes and looked at the middle?aged man behind the desk, the one with thinning hair and a stern face.

“It may be that Protocol Twenty?Two was activated,” the Harbor’s defense commander, Lister, said in a low voice. “The situation might have been too urgent, or there was a risk of a memetic leak, or the Sea Swallow had fallen completely under someone else’s control, so no message could come back. Though that still doesn’t explain why the Sea Swallow’s wreckage disappeared so cleanly.”

In the office, the officers looked at each other. The words “Protocol Twenty?Two” pressed down on them, making the already heavy mood even more suffocating.

In that weighty silence, Commander Lister paused for a moment, then went on: “I know General Duncan. If the Sea Swallow really ran into an supernatural corruption it could not resist, he would use Protocol Twenty? Two without hesitation. So in the next stage, our job is not only to keep searching for possible traces of the Sea Swallow. We also have to figure out what attacked and corrupted that ship. If there really is an attacker, it may not have a physical form. That would be a huge threat to Frostholm.”

“An attacker…” The female officer who had spoken earlier grew more serious. “If this attacker really exists, do you think it wasn’t destroyed along with the Sea Swallow’s Protocol Twenty?Two?”

“One of the basic rules when dealing with an supernatural disaster,” Lister said slowly, “is that unless you have enough strong, direct proof, you always assume the enemy is still there. Whether it’s an supernatural object or an supernatural phenomenon, its ‘vitality’ is always frighteningly strong.”

The officers exchanged looks again. One of them spoke up, hesitating: “Then about Dagger Island…”

“I’ll submit a request for an investigation to the governor,” Lister said as he slowly rose and braced his hands on the desk. “The Sea Swallow had its accident on the way back to the main island, and when it left Dagger Island it did report that the inspection work there had gone smoothly. But now the ship has had an accident, which means the situation on Dagger Island is also in doubt. Next, you will—”

The defense commander did not finish his sentence. Sudden hurried footsteps sounded in the hallway, followed by a sharp knock at the door that cut him off.

Lister frowned and said: “Come in.”

A secretary pushed the door open, saluted the commander behind the desk, and said: “Commander, Gatekeeper Agatha is here.”

“Gatekeeper?” Surprise clearly showed on Lister’s face. “What is she here for?”

“She says it is about the Sea Swallow. The situation is urgent.”

“Let her—” Lister started at once, but before he finished speaking, an Ashen Wind swirled up in the hallway outside. The pale, dust?like Ashen Wind rushed into the room and quickly spun around the office. Agatha stepped out of the Ashen Wind. She held the tin Gatekeeper’s cane always carried by priests of the Death God. The gaze that showed between her bandages was serious, with a hint of apology.

“Sorry, Colonel Lister. The situation is urgent. I came in as soon as I heard your answer,” Agatha nodded and said. “I want to know how far your investigation into the Sea Swallow’s whereabouts has gone.”

Lister showed no displeasure at Agatha barging into the office. A good soldier knew what mattered most, and the city?state’s Gatekeeper had many special rights in emergencies. For this lady to appear in such a hurry clearly meant things were too urgent for polite formalities.

“We still haven’t found any trace or wreckage of the Sea Swallow. We currently suspect that General Duncan used Protocol Twenty?Two and the Sea Swallow has already sunk,” he said gravely. “Next, we plan to widen the search area, look for signs of the attacker in the open sea, and prepare to investigate Dagger Island.”

“Your guess about Protocol Twenty?Two is correct. The Sea Swallow was indeed invaded and corrupted by an supernatural force. The ship has already fulfilled its duty with honor, but you must not rush to investigate Dagger

Island," Agatha said quickly. "That island may already be in a full runaway state."

"Dagger Island is in a runaway state?" The muscles in Lister's face clearly twitched. "What information do you have?"

"…The source of the information is not convenient to reveal for now," Agatha hesitated. "But it is very reliable. I haven't had time to report to the great Cathedral and City Hall yet, because that might delay things. Colonel Lister, I hope you will immediately seal off all routes around Dagger Island. No ship is allowed to approach, and nothing is allowed to leave that island —most of all, nothing is allowed to land on Frostholm's main island."

"Lady Agatha, I must remind you—this does not follow procedure," Lister said, his tone growing more serious. "I'm willing to trust your judgment as Gatekeeper, but you should know every rule was written in lives. Sending out the navy to seal off Dagger Island is no small matter. I need clearer orders and explanations."

"At least this won't make things worse," Agatha took half a step forward. "I've already sent people to the great Cathedral. Follow?up orders will come soon."

Lister opened his mouth as if to say more, but just then a sudden, sharp bell rang from a corner of the room, cutting him off.

The Harbor's defense commander glanced at Agatha, then turned and quickly walked to a small side table. He pressed a button on the table.

Moments later, hissing air and a rapid, growing clatter sounded inside a copper tube fixed to the wall near the table. With a light metallic bang, the tube shook. A latch at the end of the pipe popped open and a bit of white vapor puffed out.

Lister opened the latch, flipped up the cover, took out the capsule inside the tube, and pulled out the slip of paper. He glanced over it, and his face changed at once.

“What is it?” Agatha asked, curious.

“A ship has appeared in the Nearshore Waters and sent a request to enter the harbor,” Lister slowly lifted his head. His face was grim. “It’s the Sea Swallow.”

The room fell quiet at once.

The officers looked at each other. Agatha’s gaze turned solemn in an instant. Lister stayed silent for a few seconds, then suddenly said: “To the docks.”

The Sea Swallow had appeared. After being missing for more than twenty? four hours, it showed itself again to the people of Frostholm and sailed straight toward the military pier of East Harbor.

From the watchtower on the East Harbor pier, they could already see the outline of the steam cruiser. It grew larger on the horizon, steam rising above it like clouds.

“Silhouette and bow flag match… It’s the Sea Swallow.”

A junior officer lowered his telescope and spoke in a complicated tone.

Lister still did not move. He kept his gaze fixed on the dark shape on the sea that was slowly drawing closer and did not say a word for a long time.

The faint sound of the whistle drifted over, with a special rhythm of pauses.

“Second?round signal. The Sea Swallow is requesting entry to port,” the junior officer turned and looked at Lister. “Commander…”

“Sink it.” Agatha, who had been silent this whole time, finally broke the silence.

Chapter 344:

“Sink it.”

Agatha kept her eyes locked on the ship that was moving steadily closer across the sea. Her voice was as cold and hard as ice.

The junior officer beside her looked stunned, as if he could not believe what he had heard: “Ma’am, what did you say?”

“Sink it.” Agatha did not answer the young officer. She only turned her head toward Colonel Lister and repeated: “That is the ‘raider’, a massive source of corruption. I do not know what it really is, but it is definitely not the Sea Swallow.”

As she spoke, she paused. Her fingers tightened on the Gatekeeper’s cane until her knuckles turned a little white: “I will take responsibility for this decision.”

Lister said nothing. The muscles in his face were tight, and for a long time he stood in the cold wind like a statue frozen in place. Only when the whistle sounded again in the distance, clearer and louder than before, carrying a disturbing note of urgency, did he suddenly break the silence: “Lady, are you sure your source is reliable?”

“…I trust my own judgment, Colonel,” Agatha drew a slow breath, her voice rough and a little husky. “And I will take responsibility for it.”

“You cannot take responsibility. You are the Gatekeeper, but you are not the direct overseer of the Harbor system,” Lister said calmly. Then he turned

around and looked out toward the distant sea.

“Sink that ship. I will take responsibility for this decision.”

Far out on the sea, the ship that had suddenly appeared, the “Sea Swallow”, was still racing ahead at full speed. Its tall prow cut through the waves. Its flags snapped and cracked in the wind. The funnel at midships spewed out great billows of white vapor. Within those clouds, it seemed as if countless hidden howls rose and fell in a constant, snarling uproar.

At the Sea Swallow’s stern, the broken wake heaved and crossed over itself. Deep within the layers of foaming spray, black, sticky matter spread with the waves like blood pouring from a giant beast’s body, drifting in fine strands that rose and sank with the swell.

“Woooo-”

The whistle sounded again. More great sheets of white vapor burst from the top of the Ironclad Warship. High-pressure Tathagata steam from the Deep Sea seemed to scream as it tore through the sky.

Shapes moved along the Sea Swallow’s rail. Figures walked back and forth, busy and hurried. They wore the uniforms of the Frostholm navy and did the tasks that seamen on a warship were supposed to do. They stepped over the jagged cracks that split the deck. They stepped over the sticky, writhing substance underfoot and the swollen nodules that crossed the planks like thick, tangled veins.

Melted-looking black sludge kept dripping off the bodies of those seamen. Some of the seamen suddenly fell where they stood and sank into the nearby structures of the ship, becoming one with steel and planks. At the same time, new seamen kept separating themselves from the deck or the ship’s side. They wriggled, crawled, and staggered away, to scrub the deck, to handle the flags, to turn on the lights…

They were going home. The Sea Swallow was going home.

But far away, in the direction of the Harbor, the heavy platforms of the Coastal Guns had already started to move. One after another, the armored doors set into the cliffs, sea walls, and the Harbor's reinforced concrete outer walls opened up. Dark cannon barrels pushed out. Massive gun mounts slowly turned under the drive of gears and linkages.

Deep underground, the Shaft Lift creaked as it ran, sending shells up from the buried magazines to the giant guns above. At the same time, rapid bells and whistles rang out in and around the Harbor, urging all ships still outside the Harbor to clear the area at once and pushing every facility within the Harbor into a state of battle readiness.

The Sea Swallow seemed to feel something. Even before the air-raid sirens on Frostholm's main island began to sound, it had already started to speed up.

Steam gushed. The whistle screamed without pause. The whole ship seemed to be howling from the inside out. Seamen on the deck broke into a run. In the white vapor above the funnel, streaks of black and dark red appeared before anyone knew it.

The ship was accelerating. It was already a fast steamship, but now its speed rose to the limit. It raced across the wide, endless sea like a giant beast wrapped in rolling thunder. The roar of waves split by its bow grew, little by little, into a wild scream that shook the whole ocean.

At that moment, the Coastal Guns on Frostholm's main island opened fire.

Like thunder bursting apart overhead, the huge coastal guns spat flame and noise. Their terrible power shook the air. A first full volley of standard armor-piercing shells roared out. The pointed shells screamed through the

sky and lit fierce fire-lines across it, then fell onto the distant sea after a long arc of flight.

Shells plunged into the water. Columns of spray shot up everywhere. Tall and short water plumes rose all around the Sea Swallow and turned the sea far away into a drifting, spreading fog bank. A few shells grazed the Sea Swallow, but its speed did not drop at all.

The shock of the Coastal Guns' fire even made the platform under Agatha's feet tremble. She could feel the whole lookout tower quiver slightly under the feedback of that salvo. At the same time, she heard someone giving a report beside her.

"The hit rate in the first volley is low. That ship is too fast. It is faster than any speed on record!"

"Open free fire. Switch to armor-piercing incendiary shells. Keep firing until the target sinks," Lister said with no expression. "The stationed fleet is to stand by. If we still cannot stop that ship at the coastal warning line, the fleet will attack. Even if they have to ram it in the end, they must stop that ship outside Frostholm!"

"Yes, Commander!"

Lister's face was dark as still water. While the roar of the guns kept rolling, he stared hard at the rising water plumes and smoke on the distant sea, and at the "Sea Swallow" that was still speeding toward Frostholm. There was no hesitation left in his eyes.

From what he could see now, he could already be certain that this ship was not the Sea Swallow he knew.

Faced with the bombardment from Frostholm's main island, that ship had not slowed down. It had not sent the proper signal flags or signal lights.

Instead, it kept speeding up, pushing past the limits of its own design… That was not a warship of Frostholm. That was a Monster.

A Monster disguised as a thing of the mortal world.

All the Coastal Guns began to howl. In the roar of continuous fire, armor-piercing incendiary shells drew countless bright lines across the sky and fell like crossing rain into the waters around the Sea Swallow. Huge columns of water shot up one after another. In the forest of water plumes, the ship that kept shrieking and roaring rushed straight ahead like a wild beast driven mad.

As the distance shrank and the barrage was corrected again and again, shells finally began to land directly on the Sea Swallow.

Massive blasts tore its armor open. They smashed its masts and peeled whole sheets of deck plating from the hull. Black, mud-like sludge gushed from under its fake shell like blood. It poured down on the sea in a dark rain.

“God of Death above! What is that thing?!”

Through their telescopes, the people on the lookout tower could now just make out the twisted, strange shapes under the Sea Swallow’s shattered deck. Someone could not hold back a low cry.

Lister only watched with a grave face. The muscles at his jaw were still tight.

The ship did not slow down.

Even after the Coastal Guns had ripped apart its stern deck, blown off its funnel and bridge, and blasted the compartments that should have held its ammunition and steam core, it still did not slow down.

The Coastal Guns kept howling. Salvo after salvo of deadly shells crashed down. A huge number of guns focused their “attention” on a single enemy ship that never tried to dodge. In a very short time, they poured an uncountable number of shells onto the Sea Swallow. For any normal ship, this would already have been fatal.

Even if it did not sink, it should at least have stopped.

But it was still running at full speed.

Soon, the other people on the tower also noticed what was happening on the sea, and tension began to spread.

“Keep firing, until it vanishes from the surface of the sea,” Lister said through clenched teeth. Then he suddenly turned to Agatha at his side. “Lady, please inform the Cathedral as soon as possible. If we cannot stop it on the Harbor side, we may need to…”

“Do not be so quick to give up yet, Colonel,” Agatha shook her head before he could finish. “The attack is working. It is fading.”

As she spoke, she looked out over the distant sea. In the eyes of the young Gatekeeper, a pale light flickered gently.

What her eyes reflected was not the Mortal Realm, but the Spirit Realm.

Agatha saw the twisted black silhouette breaking apart. On the chaotic sea, crooked lines of light and shadow were peeling away from that shape at great speed.

The barrage from the Coastal Guns had not directly “killed” the replica, but it was driving it toward some critical point. It was about to collapse on its own.

Agatha blinked. The brief image of the Spirit Realm faded from her sight, and the clear world of the Mortal Realm returned to her eyes.

The Coastal Guns kept firing. Soon, more gunfire sounded from not far away.

That was the fleet inside the Harbor. It had finally finished its preparations and joined the interception.

The roar of the battleships' main guns became the final straw that broke the "Sea Swallow". When even more armor-piercing incendiary shells rained down on the ship that was already beyond recognition, it finally began to fall apart.

First its deck and outer hull tore away in huge sheets, exposing the twisted, dark structures inside. Then the whole ship writhed and ripped from bow to stern, as if it was trying to tear itself into pieces. The thing that had once looked like the Sea Swallow now flung out endless black muck as it snapped apart.

Its whistle finally fell silent. The strange, sharp wails slowly died away.

It began to slow down. As it spread vast patches of dark filth across the sea, it also melted and caved in on itself.

This terrible, eerie attacker that had tried to charge into the civilized world finally came to a stop only a few nautical miles from Frostholm's main island.

Chapter 345:

The “Sea Swallow” had stopped.

By the time this terrifying charger came to a halt, it had almost turned into a heap of wreckage under the constant bombardment. Its original hull structure was completely gone. There was not even a single intact stretch of deck or superstructure left. Broken hull plates and inner matter were scattered across the sea like spilled garbage. Between the shattered remnants floated slowly spreading pools of black sludge. Patches of fire still burned among the fragments, and thick, dirty smoke rolled up into the sky.

Along the path where the Sea Swallow had once charged, the water was filled with that strange, mud-like substance. The ominous black color drew a band across the sea that ran for more than ten nautical miles, like the slime trail a soft-bodied creature might leave when crawling ashore. It rose and fell slowly with the waves and wind, refusing to disperse.

The howling of the Coastal Guns had fallen silent. The harsh smell of powder smoke hung over the whole coastline. Lister kept his gaze fixed on the burning wreckage out at sea. Only after a long time did he dare to believe that thing had really stopped completely, and he broke the silence with some hesitation: “Is it over?”

“…It might also be only the beginning,” Agatha’s voice was slightly hoarse. Pale light flashed now and then in her eyes. Even though the “Sea Swallow” had stopped moving, she still watched the scenes in the Spirit Realm over and over, unwilling to relax until she was sure nothing in those

remains was still drifting toward the city-state. “Do not forget, the Sea Swallow only went wrong after it returned from Dagger Island.”

Lister’s expression grew very ugly.

“When was the last message from that island?”

“Just a few hours ago. The telegram said everything on the island was normal,” Lister said, brow deeply furrowed. “The Spirit Realm link with the Cathedral has also been steady the whole time.”

“…Seal off Dagger Island, Colonel. From this moment on, do not trust any message that comes from that island,” Agatha let out a long breath. “I will return to the main Cathedral at once. I believe a stricter blockade order will be issued very soon.”

“Thank you for your help, Lady Agatha.”

“Everything is for the peace of the city-state,” Agatha said softly. She recited a short saying from the Sacred Tome of Death. “All things in order.”

…

Half an hour earlier.

Thunder-like booms had rolled in from far away, one after another, each volley denser than the last. From the direction of the sound, it seemed to come from the coastline on the eastern side of the city-state.

Duncan lifted his head and looked toward that part of the sky. Through the haze, he could faintly see clouds rising in that direction.

“What was that sound?” Alice nervously touched her head and looked at Duncan in confusion. “Was that thunder?”

“It sounded like heavy guns,” Vanna, standing to the side, had already gone a little pale. “The Coastal Guns? What happened? Why would there be a

full volley from the Coastal Guns…”

A thoughtful look came over Duncan’s face. The first thing he thought of was the denunciation letter he had handed to the Old Caretaker. Right after that, he thought of the direction where Dagger Island lay.

[Did I really guess right?]

The sound of wings suddenly came from nearby. A fat, plain-looking pigeon burst out of the shadows of a nearby building, flapped hard, and flew quickly into the distance.

“No need to worry. I sent AI to go check,” Duncan said. Then he raised his head and looked at the slightly old house in front of them. “Now, keep telling me about this place.”

Morris cleared his throat at once and went on with the introduction that had been cut off. The distant rumbling still rolled now and then, but since the captain was so calm, there clearly was nothing to panic about. “Vanna and I picked this house out of four rental options. The other three were either too close to the city center, which would make it hard for us to move around, or they were in poor condition and unfit to live in. This one is old too, but the landlady has taken good care of it. It is quite clean inside.

“This house is Number 44, Oak Street. Next to it is Hearth Street. The landlady has another home over on Hearth Street, so she will not come here and bother us in normal times. There is a small lane linking the two blocks, and the small Cathedral sits on a little square between them, a bit of a walk from here…

“We signed a short-term lease. The average daily rent is higher than for a long-term contract, but we can move out at any time. Right now we have paid half a month in advance. Vanna and I have already met the landlady.

She is a rather kind and well-bred lady. When she learned I am a traveling scholar, she very generously brought over some basic daily supplies…”

Duncan listened to the old gentleman’s careful explanation while he studied their temporary lodging.

It was a detached house with the typical style of a northern city-state. The gray-white outer walls were a little rough, coated with porous plaster that kept in heat. The building had two floors. Its windows were fairly narrow. A black front door stood under a wall lamp and beside a mail slot. The roof was steep and high, covered with black tiles so that snow would melt and slide off easily. Steam and gas pipes ran out from the thick main pipes that crossed above the street, then followed the gable down into the building.

It was not a luxurious home, but it was more than enough as a temporary base. It was even a little more spacious than the small two-story building in Pland that had held both shop and lodgings.

Letting Morris and Vanna handle the problem of where to stay had clearly been the right choice. No one else on the ship could have managed it.

Morris stepped forward, took the key from his pocket, and opened the front door. Duncan followed him in with Alice right behind.

Inside the door was an entryway for taking off shoes and outerwear. Beyond that lay a fairly roomy parlor. The walls were covered with light-patterned wallpaper that had yellowed a little with age. The dining room opened directly off the parlor. Another bedroom sat beside the dining room. A staircase to the second floor faced the front door. It seemed that most of the bedrooms were on the upper floor.

The floorboards felt a bit loose underfoot and gave off a soft creak that spoke of passing years. Plain tables and chairs shone faintly in the sunlight.

There was hardly any dust to be seen. On the dining table sat a bright bouquet of flowers in vivid colors. It was clearly made of cloth or plastic.

“That was from the landlady as well. They say it is a custom here in Frostholm,” Morris explained. “The landlord gives new tenants a bouquet that will not wither in winter. It stands for health and safety.”

“Every place has its own little customs,” Duncan said with a small smile. “This place is not bad. And it is away from the main street, so it should be pretty quiet most of the time.”

As he spoke, he looked up toward the second floor. “We could bring Nina and Shirley over here to do their homework. They have already started complaining that they are bored on the ship.”

The corner of Vanna’s mouth twitched. “…Shirley is probably really bored, but I doubt she wants to come into the city to do homework.”

Duncan waved a hand. “It does not matter. She should put in some effort anyway. Dog can already more or less read the newspaper, and Shirley is still fighting with the spelling of twelve common vegetables. I am deeply worried about her future. At this rate she will not even be able to catch up with Alice.”

Alice, who was in truth not doing much better than Shirley, scratched her hair and gave a harmless-looking grin. “Hehe…”

Duncan’s face stayed blank. “I am not praising you. The fact that you and Shirley together do not know more words than a dog is nothing to be proud of.”

Alice froze for a moment, as if she were seriously trying to figure out whether the words she and Shirley knew together actually added up to more than Dog’s vocabulary. While she was stuck on this question, the faint rumbling from far away finally began to fade.

“The sound stopped…” Vanna tilted her head, listening to the distance.

Duncan did not speak. Through the hazy mental link, he sensed what AI was seeing far away.

After so much practice and adjustment, the bond between him and AI was now much tighter and clearer than at the very start. When he focused enough, he could even share AI’s sight and some of its other senses. He could also use AI as a relay to send out a portion of his power without moving his true body at all.

In the Harbor district on the eastern side of Frostholm, the chubby White Dove stood on top of a tower. One round little eye watched the smoke-covered sea, and the other looked back toward the Harbor itself.

The soldiers running back and forth across the Harbor and the spreading black “oil slick” on the sea were reflected in its eyes, where green fire flickered softly.

“There is no need to worry for now,” Duncan pulled his distant “sight” back and gave Morris and Vanna a slight nod. “There was an invasion, but the people of Frostholm have already stopped it.”

Vanna’s face changed at once. “An invasion?!”

“If I am not wrong, it came from Dagger Island. The people of Frostholm should already have realized how serious the problem is. Whatever is on that island will not find it so easy to get out again,” Duncan said in a calm tone. “Tyrian has already reached the waters near Dagger Island. His sea-fog fleet will make the authority in Frostholm even more tense. In any case, once the whole city goes under martial law, the Annihilators hiding in the city will have to move. When that happens, it will be much easier to smoke them out.”

Just then, a knock at the door suddenly sounded, cutting off their talk in the parlor.

Duncan looked toward the door in surprise. They had only just moved in. A guest already?

“I will get it,” Morris said, and he walked to the door. When he opened it, a surprised sound came out of him. “You are…”

A small young lady in a thick white coat and a knitted hat was standing at the door.

Chapter 346: Blockade

The young lady standing at the door looked at most eleven or twelve years old. She was short and wore a warm, thick white coat, and a bit of steam rose from her wool hat—she seemed to have run all the way here. When she saw Morris she was still out of breath, but a bright smile soon bloomed on her face.

“You’re Grandpa Morris, right? Mother asked me to bring this,” she said as she held out her hand and passed over a key. “It’s the basement key. Mother said she forgot to give it to you when she left.”

“Ah, thank you, little young lady,” Morris said, coming back to his senses. He took the key and nodded. “Come in and warm up for a bit?”

The young lady was just about to speak when Duncan’s voice suddenly sounded from behind Morris, with a hint of surprise: “Annie?”

Looking past the old scholar’s shoulder, Duncan gazed in some astonishment at the girl standing in the doorway.

It was Annie Barbelli, the girl he had seen earlier at the cemetery gate—the daughter of Captain Cristo Barbelli of the Obsidian.

Duncan already understood what had happened. He did not know whether to call it a coincidence or to sigh over how “small” the city-state was. After going around in circles, he had met the Obsidian captain’s daughter again. The temporary lodging that Morris and Vanna had spent a whole day finding… turned out to be Annie’s family home.

Annie also saw the tall, broad figure that suddenly appeared in front of her, and her eyes instantly widened.

The unexpected situation left the young lady a bit at a loss. She stared blankly for several seconds before she finally reacted and greeted him clumsily: “Ah, it’s the uncle from the cemetery gate… you… hel-hello?”

Her last greeting was clearly hesitant. She was obviously remembering what had happened at the cemetery gate, remembering that strange sight when Duncan left and flames soared into the sky. Duncan had not thought much of it at the time, but that scene had clearly left a deep mark in the young lady’s mind.

Even though she was still young, Annie knew that it had been the power of the supernatural. Knowledge of such things had long been written into every city-state’s textbooks and spread through the common education for all citizens. A basic understanding of supernatural powers and simple protection skills was the foundation that allowed ordinary people to live safely in this world.

But Annie still could not tell what kind of power it was. Her textbooks had never talked about it. Grandpa Caretaker at the cemetery had not explained it to her. When she went home and told Mother, Mother also told her nothing.

It felt like a secret that a small child was not supposed to touch yet.

Annie stared blankly at Duncan standing opposite her. Grandpa Caretaker’s earlier warning still echoed in her ears, and it made her instinctively uneasy. But then the tall figure suddenly stepped to the side, and his voice, which sounded a bit frightening yet carried a trace of warmth, said: “Come in and rest for a while. It’s starting to snow again outside.”

Only then did Annie belatedly turn her head to look back. She saw swirling snowflakes falling from the sky once more. A few flakes rode the wind down her collar, cold as ice against her neck.

She walked into the house as if pulled by unseen hands, looking around in a daze.

The sister with the beautiful blond hair and noble air was also standing in the living room, beside the dining table, watching them with curious eyes.

She had taken off her veil. She looked very beautiful—almost the most beautiful person Annie had ever seen.

“Mother said I shouldn’t bother the tenants,” Annie said, rubbing the dirt and melted snow from her little boots on the mat at the entrance, still speaking hesitantly. “She said Grandpa Morris is a Grand Scholar, and it would be very rude to make trouble…”

“You’re not bothering us. We were just thinking about learning a bit more about our new place,” Morris said at once, having more or less guessed the situation. “And it’s snowing again outside. It’s not safe for you to run back along the little paths. Rest here for a while. Later Vanna will walk you home.”

Annie looked up at Vanna, who was like a little giant, and nodded without thinking.

Then she looked toward Duncan. She hesitated for a few seconds before she spoke: “So… so you also need to live in a house?”

“Of course I live in a house,” Duncan said with a laugh. As he led Annie toward the sofa in the living room, he added casually: “You run around outside all by yourself. Doesn’t your Mother worry?”

In his view, Annie really ran around too wildly. She had not only gone to the cemetery alone early in the morning, but now, in this awful weather, she

had run through the alleys between blocks to bring a key to new tenants whose background she did not even know. That was truly worrying.

“It’s not that bad. Everyone around here knows me. Mother says half the people on these two streets were Dad’s friends,” Annie said, not caring at all. She sat down on the sofa, braced her hands under her thighs, and swung her body back and forth. “And Mother is usually very busy. She has to keep accounts and fill in forms for people. When she has time, she also goes to help at the little cathedral. I’ve gotten used to running around.”

Duncan thought for a moment and asked: “Then… when you went home, did you tell your Mother what I told you?”

“I told her,” Annie said with a nod. Then her expression turned a bit strange. “At first she said I was talking nonsense. Later I told her what Grandpa Caretaker at the cemetery said. Then she went back to her room alone… When she came out, it looked like she had been crying… but she smiled and told me we would have fried fish fillets and sausage stew for dinner, because today is a day worth celebrating.”

She stopped swinging her body and looked a little confused. She raised her head to look at Duncan and said, curious and hesitant: “I feel like… I don’t really understand.”

“It’s all right. You’ll understand sooner or later,” Duncan said with a smile. “Some things are too complicated for you right now.”

“Uncle, you talk just like Grandpa Caretaker. He says that a lot too,” Annie muttered. Then she shook her head, as if she had thought very seriously for a while, and looked up again. “Uncle, do you… not want to be bothered by people?”

Duncan was curious: “Why do you say that?”

“Because of the way you dress—and because you suddenly disappeared when you left. Mother says that is the style of the secret staff from the Grand Cathedral, or of the hermits in those societies… I think that was the word, ‘style’.”

For a moment Duncan did not know how to answer the young lady. But she clearly did not wait for his reply. Annie thought to herself for a bit and then suddenly said: “I won’t just go and tell anyone. Grandpa Caretaker reminded me too. He told me to act as if I never met you and not tell anyone except Mother.”

Duncan let out a silent laugh, but before he could speak, Annie went on: “Then can I tell Grandpa Caretaker? Tell him… you’re living in my family’s house?”

Morris and Vanna, who had come over by the sofa to listen in, could not help looking at each other when they heard the young lady’s words. Alice at once turned her eyes to Duncan.

They all felt that something about this was not quite right.

However, Duncan only stayed silent for a few seconds, then nodded slightly with a smile: “You can. I don’t mind.”

…

At the same time, near the eastern Harbor, the work of collecting samples from the wreck of the Sea Swallow had already begun.

Several light, fast boats left the docks and carefully approached that patch of sea where foul “sludge” and a few tongues of flame still floated. Each boat carried a priest and a sacred relic, as well as nitroglycerin charges for emergencies.

On shore, the Harbor garrison was also ready to receive them.

An empty warehouse had been chosen as a temporary transfer facility. priests and Guardians who had rushed over from the higher Cathedral had already finished the purification and countermeasures for the whole area. Before leaving, Gatekeeper Agatha had left behind a squad of elite trusted aides to guard against accidents during the collection of the wreck samples.

Lister stood on the pier, watching the situation on the sea. Several of his trusted subordinate aides stood nearby, keeping an eye on the progress of the salvage work.

“Are we sure bringing those things ashore won’t cause any problems?” one trusted aide asked, unease in his voice. “Of course, I am not questioning the Gatekeeper’s judgment, but those things… a few hours ago, they were rushing toward Frostholm Island at a terrifying speed. Are they really ‘dead’ now?”

“Lady Agatha made repeated deep checks in the Spirit Realm. These things are no longer active,” Lister said calmly. “They really can be ‘killed’. Judging from Lady Agatha’s attitude and how she handled it, I think the Grand Cathedral may already have dealt with similar things before.”

“Similar things? They have already appeared inside the city-state?” a junior officer said in shock. “I… I never heard any news like that…”

“If you haven’t heard, that only shows this matter should not be made public yet, or at least not yet. The Grand Cathedral and City Hall have their own judgment,” Lister said with a shake of his head. “In any case, Lady Agatha is trustworthy. She would not risk the city-state’s safety. What we need to do is follow the experts’ judgment—the priests know much better than soldiers how to deal with such strange things.”

The trusted aide fell silent. But just then, another burst of hurried footsteps sounded, and a soldier came quickly up onto the pier.

“Commander!” The soldier trotted over to Lister, saluted, and handed the Defense Commander a document that had just arrived through the Pneumatic Tube System. “Orders from City Hall.”

“Looks like the formal order to seal off Dagger Island has arrived,” Lister said as he took the document. But when he saw what was written, his expression suddenly changed.

One trusted aide noticed. “Commander? Is something wrong?”

“…It is indeed an order to block sea routes, but not to seal off Dagger Island.” Lister’s face grew grim, and his tone became especially serious. “Strictly speaking, it is not only Dagger Island. The order demands that all routes in and out of Frostholm be sealed, and all garrison troops go into battle readiness.”

“Seal… the whole main island of Frostholm?!”

“The Sea Mist Fleet has appeared in the nearby waters,” Lister said, drawing in a slow breath. His face looked even darker than the sky. “The entire Sea Mist Fleet.”

Chapter 347: The Silent Grand Cathedral

The Sea Mist Fleet had come, out in full force.

For a full half century, this famous curse Fleet had always hung like a blade over the heads of the people of Frostholm. It was the legacy of Frostholm's Queen, the shadow that never faded after the Great Uprising fifty years ago. It stood upon the Frost Sea like a sheer iceberg, its cold, hard hull hiding the unfathomable mind of the undying pirate general within.

Whenever people of Frostholm spoke of it, they could not help lowering their voices.

Almost everyone who knew history understood that the Frostholm rebellion fifty years ago had not succeeded because of "justice" or "blessing". The ragged rebels who rose up back then had been able to defeat the strongest royal fleet in history for one main reason: the Queen's most powerful main fleet had simply not been on Frostholm's main island at the time.

No one knew why the Sea Mist Fleet had left back then, just as no one knew what truth Frostholm's Queen had learned from the Deep Sea in those days. People only knew one thing: to this day, that fleet still acted in the Queen's name.

For half a century, the powerful Sea Mist Fleet had wandered through these Northern Seas like a ghost. Some city-states had tried to wipe out or reclaim this fleet, but they had never succeeded. On the other hand, although the Undying captains of those cursed warships roamed the Frost Sea, most

ships that met them only needed to hand over money to avoid disaster. Compared with the losses from fighting the Sea Mist Fleet head-on, that “toll” was more like a kind and cheap tax. The northern city-states would rather pay for peace than risk themselves to repay Frostholm’s fifty-year-old debt.

But the people of Frostholm themselves knew that the Sea Mist Fleet would one day return. It was like a curse, and had even become a “prophecy of legend” that many Frostholm people grew up hearing again and again—

As long as the flag of the Sea Mist Fleet still flew, the Queen of Frostholm had not finished ruling this city-state. As long as the Sea Mist’s engines still turned, the reckoning for that Great Uprising fifty years ago would sooner or later fall upon this city.

The curse and the rumors passed from mouth to mouth had far-reaching effects. Under these stories, year after year, the cold shadow of the Sea Mist Fleet had only grown more frightening. Even well-trained professional soldiers could not ignore that pressure.

Lister’s fingers tightened slightly on the document until his knuckles turned a little white.

And as his words fell, a strange and heavy silence settled over the whole pier.

This Defense Commander knew that information about the Sea Mist Fleet did not need to be kept secret. That huge fleet was sailing openly right beside Frostholm, and it was still drawing closer to the main island and Dagger Island. By the time the Sun rose tomorrow at the latest, residents living near the coast would only need to open their windows, raise a telescope toward the southeast, and they would see those hazy ship silhouettes. This news would spread through the city-state very soon.

“The Sea Mist Fleet… the Sea Mist Fleet suddenly appearing, could it be connected to what happened on Dagger Island?” one trusted officer said. “Could it be tied to that ‘Sea Swallow’ that appeared out of nowhere?”

“I would rather they were connected. Then at least we would only face one problem,” Lister said through his teeth. “The worse possibility is that we are looking at two separate troubles…”

Another trusted officer sounded nervous: “Will the Sea Mist Fleet strike while the iron is hot? While Frostholm’s main island is being threatened by some unknown power…”

“It is too early to make any judgments. Carrying out the orders is our first duty,” Lister said, cutting off his subordinates’ wild guesses and speaking quickly. “Arrange the blockade at once. Send martial law signals to the nearby city-states and ships along the route. All Coastal Guns positions are to stand by… We may be in serious trouble.”

…

In the heartland of the Frostholm city-state, just like in most seafaring city-states, the solemn, towering Grand Cathedral stood on the highest ground at the very center of the city.

The locals called it the Silent Grand Cathedral, or simply “the Grand Cathedral”.

It was an ancient and solemn building, almost entirely made of gray and black bricks. Clusters of slender buildings and all kinds of spires formed its body. Whenever the heavy winter snow flew, those layers of spires became hazy against the snowy sky, like rows of tombstones in the mist or black swords pointing at the heavens.

When outsiders first came to Frostholm and saw this Cathedral, their first feeling was often that it was too gloomy and oppressive, even a little

frightening. But for the people of Frostholm, who almost all believed in the God of Death Bartok, this black Grand Cathedral held only solemn dignity and holiness.

The locals firmly believed that the many spires of the Cathedral were bridges between the realm of death and the mortal world. When the days of heavy snow came, the God of Death's envoys would hide among those spires and rooftops. With eyes that saw through all things, they would cast their gaze over the city-state and guide back to rest those undead who had lost their way for all sorts of reasons.

Thus the people of Frostholm saw the first day of heavy snow as "the day when long-lost restless souls set out on their way". On that day, they would close the cemeteries and pause all funerals for new dead, so as to leave the roads wide and clear for those long-lost restless souls, letting them reach the Silent Grand Cathedral in time.

Today was one of those days of heavy snow.

The nearby cemeteries were closed, and the Grand Cathedral no longer allowed anyone but the Clergy to go in and out. The cloister paths in the courtyard, where snowflakes kept falling, were quieter than ever. Other than the sound of boots on snow, even the soft patter of snow slipping from the treetops could be heard clearly.

Agatha, wearing a wide-brimmed hat and dressed all in black, passed through the Cathedral's courtyard gate. She walked through the long audience hall and then deeper inside, until she reached the Meditation Chapel where the Bishop stayed.

As in Pland, Frostholm also had two top spokespeople for the Church. The "Gatekeeper" was the guardian of the city-state's security and mainly handled worldly affairs. The city-state's Bishop mainly took charge of clerical work and of dealing with the higher powers of divine authority.

Inside the Meditation Chapel, candle flames flickered in rows of niches along the walls. The pale light from countless candles made the room quite bright. At the far end of the chapel stood a high stone platform. Yet on that platform there was no statue or chair, only a simple black coffin with an ancient look.

That was where the city-state's Bishop stayed.

Agatha stepped up onto the platform, looked down, and said: "I'm back."

The coffin stayed completely silent.

Agatha waited patiently for a few seconds, then raised her voice a little: "Bishop Ivan, have you heard the news that the Sea Mist Fleet has appeared?"

There was still no movement inside the coffin.

Agatha frowned and lifted her head to look around. After hesitating a little, she finally raised the Gatekeeper's cane and tapped it beside the coffin: "Are you there?"

She tapped three times in a row. At last, a hoarse, elderly voice came from inside the coffin: "I am. Stop knocking. Show some respect for the elderly."

Agatha lowered the Gatekeeper's cane: "…Did you fall asleep while meditating and giving benediction to the God of Death?"

"I was too deep in my meditation to hear any voices from the mortal world."

"But your snoring carried through the coffin lid into the mortal world."

"Ah? Was it that loud?"

Agatha sighed: "You really did fall asleep, Bishop."

The voice in the coffin fell silent at once. A few seconds later, a faint scraping broke the quiet. The dark coffin lid slid a little to the side, but only enough to leave a narrow crack. The old, raspy voice came again, now clearer: “Your heart is in turmoil, Agatha. It seems things are not going well in the city-state.”

“On my way back to the Grand Cathedral, I received the news that the Sea Mist Fleet is approaching the city-state,” Agatha said slowly. “I’m afraid this news will soon…”

“The Sea Mist Fleet should be left to the navy and the people at City Hall to worry about. Your concern is the balance in the supernatural field and the peace within the city-state,” said the voice of Frostholm’s Bishop, Ivan Romonso, from inside the coffin. “Tell me about the situation inside the city first.”

Agatha nodded at this and set the news of the Sea Mist Fleet aside for the moment. Her expression grew serious.

“A new site of ‘elements’ corruption has appeared at 42 Hearth Street. From various signs, we judge that a replica made of ‘elements’ lived in that building for a long time, until it collapsed and vanished not long ago. In addition, we found a commoner there who had clearly suffered cognitive interference…”

“cognitive interference?” Bishop Ivan cut off Agatha’s report. “What kind of cognitive interference?”

Agatha gathered her thoughts and said: “After checking the population records for the local block, we found that the replica’s ‘original person’ actually died in a shipwreck six years ago. But during all the time the replica was active… the female apprentice who lived with it never noticed this obvious Anomaly. Even after the replica collapsed and vanished and

our investigators entered the scene, she still believed her teacher was just resting upstairs."

Agatha paused here, then went on: "And… our discoveries do not end there."

"They don't?"

"There is a third force—identity unknown, but very strong. They seem to be investigating the elements as well. One of their combatants killed two rather powerful heretic priests in a nearby alley. Their investigator searched that building before our elite Guardian squad arrived. Sadly, we found no clues at all and cannot even confirm where this third force comes from."

The coffin fell silent. The quiet lasted for who knew how long before Ivan's voice sounded again: "Is there any other news?"

"Yes," Agatha took a soft breath. "Do you still remember the 'visitor' who appeared in Cemetery No. 3?"

"…Has He appeared again?!"

"Yes. He appeared again, and not only appeared—He also left behind a… 'denunciation letter'."

Chapter 348: Bishop Ivan’s Secret

Agatha took out the denunciation letter. At a glance it looked like it was written on the most common kind of stationery, slipped into an envelope made by some small local factory in Frostholm, even the ink looked plain and cheap. It had been sent to her from Cemetery No. 3. To be honest, if she did not know that the Old Caretaker would never play this kind of joke on her, Agatha would never have believed that this thing had come from an indescribable higher supernatural being.

She could not sense any supernatural power from the letter at all. But after running a few simple tests, she had already confirmed that it really did come from that higher supernatural.

From inside the dark coffin came the faint rustle of cloth. The heavy lid finally opened, slowly. A strange incense smell drifted out as a body wrapped in bandages, like a mummy, slowly sat up from within.

This was Bishop Ivan of the city?state of Frostholm. Many years ago he had lost most of his body in an accident, but Bartok’s great power had kept his life going to this day. Most of the time he had to stay inside the “spirit coffin” in the Hall of Meditation, and he only appeared in public during major rites. Even so, he was still the most popular and trusted bishop in Frostholm’s history.

His achievements and vast knowledge in the field of the supernatural were beyond doubt.

He sat up in the coffin and took the denunciation letter from Agatha. The only left eye showing outside the bandages stared at the letter for a long time. He stayed silent for a long while.

Agatha finally broke the silence: “Bishop…”

The well?traveled, well?read archbishop spoke in a muffled voice: “Give me a moment.”

Agatha waited a bit, then asked: “Have you calmed down yet?”

“…You are sure this is the one?” Bishop Ivan raised his head. Confusion flickered in that slightly yellowed eye. “Did you…”

“It really looks very ordinary. But when I tried to look at the words on it through the Spirit Realm, I lost fifteen minutes of memory on the spot,” Agatha said. She knew what the bishop wanted to ask and nodded with a serious face. “It is wrapped in power that Mortals can hardly imagine. This simple appearance… might just be that Visitor’s personal taste.”

Bishop Ivan stayed quiet for a moment, as if he still needed time to recover, then slowly spoke: “What this letter talks about… is disturbing. You have already seen that ship, the Sea Swallow. If what the letter says is true, then the Sea Swallow is only the beginning. Even the runaway state of Dagger Island is only the beginning. Whether it is the cultists in the city or the corruption caused by elements, whether it is the Sea Swallow’s return or the Anomaly on Dagger Island, everything points to the Deep Sea, to the Abyssal Trench Project from half a century ago.”

“I have already sent a warning to City Hall and applied to review those secret files that have been sealed for half a century. After that I will go to the Cathedral library. I have also assigned people to strengthen the search across the whole city and arrest those hiding cultists,” Agatha said. “But that is still not enough. We at least have to confirm what is happening on

Dagger Island right now. The greater source of corruption seems to be on that island."

Bishop Ivan thought for a moment and let out a light sigh: "If everything points to the Abyssal Trench Project… then the Sea Mist Fleet now appearing near Frostholm also seems easier to explain."

"…You think all of this is part of the Queen of Frostholm's plan from back then?" Agatha frowned. "Is the Sea Mist Fleet here today because of some order she left to that 'Steel Vice Admiral'?"

"I am not sure," Bishop Ivan shook his head. Then he suddenly looked up and met Agatha's eyes. "Agatha, in your understanding, what kind of figure is the Queen of Frostholm?"

Agatha hesitated, thinking as she spoke: "She was once a great ruler. But after a brief period of brilliant rule, she was tainted and lured by the power in the Deep Sea, and fell into a dangerous 'Mad King'. Because of her stubborn will, Frostholm formed a link to the horrors in the Deep Sea. Her terrible plan still has to be sealed away even after half a century, forbidden to be known by any ordinary person. Her life was both tragic and dangerous."

"A very standard answer. As someone of the younger generation who also has enough clearance to read some of the files from fifty years ago, your summary is quite good," Bishop Ivan said with a nod. Then his tone shifted. "But you did not really live through any of it."

Agatha said nothing. She just quietly watched the archbishop in front of her.

"I lived through it. That year, I was twenty?six, just an ordinary bishop at a small Cathedral in the dock district. You know that? That little Cathedral stood right beside the test site of the Abyssal Trench Project. I even held blessing rituals for some soldiers and officers. Later I found out that those

soldiers and officers came to the Cathedral for divine blessing because they were going to come into contact with the ‘Submersible’.”

Ivan spoke slowly, his voice low. From under the crossing bandages, he let out, bit by bit, those old things that could not be told to ordinary people.

“After the rebels broke into the palace, most of the data about the Abyssal Trench Project was sealed. Then came the sea?cliff collapse at the decapitation site, which caused panic and led to even more files being destroyed. So even for a ‘Gatekeeper’ like you, with clearance, what you can access is only the shallowest part. If I tell you now that, on the night before the city Guard Corps rose in revolt, the Queen of Frostholm came to that little Cathedral and asked me to perform a soul?sending ritual for her… what would you think?”

Agatha’s eyes widened at once.

“She was called the ‘Mad King’—and yes, in the last few months her behavior was no different from madness. Even when the whole plan had fully entered a runaway state, when people were going missing, dying, or going insane every single day, she still kept pushing the project forward. She even sealed the palace chambers, locked up the last ministers who dared to advise her, ordered the gendarmes to close the Harbor, and had anyone trying to flee Frostholm arrested… After all that, the uprising that followed was only natural. There was no way she could end well on the throne as queen…”

“Yet even so, I still believe she was never truly ‘mad’… She was very clear?headed, even…”

Ivan suddenly stopped. Maybe those old memories weighed too heavily on his mind, or maybe he was searching for the right words to describe the strange feeling he’d had back then. After a few seconds, he finally went on:

“It even felt like she was the only one in the whole city who was still awake.”

Without noticing, Agatha had leaned forward: “Why do you say that?”

“She walked into the Cathedral without any attendants. Her eyes were clear, as if she already knew her fate. She went by herself to Bartok’s statue and lit incense for herself. Then she came over and patted me on the shoulder—like this.”

Bishop Ivan raised his arm, as if re?creating that moment from half a century ago.

“She patted me and said: ‘Wake up. You’re the only one in this whole city still keeping your eyes open—come help me with something. I’m about to die.’”

Agatha suddenly felt her breath catch, like the pause in breathing between sleep and waking. In the next moment she could not help lifting a hand to her forehead. Her heart was pounding. She did not know how she was supposed to react. After a few seconds of silence, she could only ask the most direct question in her mind: “You’re the only one still keeping your eyes open in the whole city… what did she mean by that?”

“I still have not fully figured it out,” Bishop Ivan sighed, his voice muffled under the bandages. “She told me to wake up—but I was already awake. And after that, she did not explain anything. She only ordered me to follow instructions. She lay down on the mortuary slab, just like the dead, and then… I performed the soul?sending ritual for her.”

“How can you hold a soul?sending ritual for someone still alive?” Agatha stared at him in disbelief. “Did that ritual… really work?”

“Of course the living cannot undergo a soul?sending ritual. I only followed her orders and carried out the whole procedure. Naturally, nothing happened

after the ritual ended," Bishop Ivan shook his head. "I thought the ritual had no meaning. But the Queen of Frostholm seemed to have already reached her own goal. She left just like that. Before leaving, she told me one thing…"

"One thing?"

"She told me not to speak of what happened that night, or the rebels would surely take my life. When she said that, there were still a full twenty?four hours before the first units of the city Guard Corps attacked the armory."

Agatha fell silent. After an unknown time, she finally spoke in a low voice: "You never told me any of this before…"

"I have never told anyone," Bishop Ivan said softly. "At that time I was just a small bishop."

"But later you became the city?state's bishop. No one can put you on trial for 'complicity' from back then anymore. This secret…"

"I planned to take this secret to my grave. Why would I tell it?" Bishop Ivan raised his head. His cloudy yellow left eye rested on Agatha with a quiet gaze. "I know this matter is no small thing. The Queen already knew about the rebels' move and even accepted her own death. That fact alone could shake many people. But apart from its shock value, it has no meaning. The Abyssal Trench Project would still remain sealed. For most citizens, the city's stable order is what matters most. No one cares what a queen who has already been executed thought or did in her last moments. And there is another, more important reason…"

Bishop Ivan paused for a moment and let out a gentle breath.

"A more important reason is this: the Abyssal Trench Project was over. The Queen's era was over. Everything had settled. At least… that is what I have thought for the past fifty years."

Chapter 349: Snow, Fog, and Secrets

In the dark coffin, the old bishop wrapped in bandages like a mummy finally told the secret he had hidden for half a century. After that came a long silence.

Agatha’s voice broke the stillness: “But it is obvious this matter is not over.”

The old bishop did not answer, so Agatha asked again: “In your view… the strange signs that keep appearing in the city?state now, and the Shadows on Dagger Island… were those also inside the Queen of Frostholm’s calculations?”

“The Queen was not a god. She might have predicted ahead of time that rebels would try to stop her ‘mad’ actions, but she could not have predicted what would happen here fifty years later,” Bishop Ivan shook his head. He was still trying to recall the details of that night, but the time was too far away, and many things were blurred. “I honestly no longer remember everything the Queen said to me that night. During the soul?sending ritual she seemed to keep talking to me, but you know, a ritual needs full focus, and you also have to inhale incense beforehand. I… really cannot remember what she said.”

He paused and spread his hands in a helpless way: “Under normal conditions, the dead lying on the platform do not chat with the priest performing the ritual about how the ritual feels.”

Agatha stayed silent, thinking for a while before she suddenly spoke: “Can you tell me more about what it was like back then? Before the Abyssal Trench Project ended completely… what else did you see in that Cathedral?”

“…In my memory, that day it also snowed heavily, just like this year. And for a long time, all kinds of snowfall almost never stopped. The snow often covered the streets around the small Cathedral so much that people could not see the edges of the roads. Many people fell because of that,” Bishop Ivan recalled quietly. His low, dull voice seemed to pull the mind straight back to that winter half a century ago. “People who slipped and got hurt often came to the Cathedral for help—because the clinics in the district were already packed full.”

“At that time, the Abyssal Trench Project had already caused great unease in the city. It was not yet a taboo subject like it is today. The core parts were secret, but ordinary people still knew there was this ‘exploring the sea’ plan. So people who came to the Cathedral often told me about the ‘strange things’ they thought they had seen…”

“Strange things?” Agatha could not help asking.

“Yes, strange things. Some said they saw lights in houses that had been empty for a long time. Some said a familiar neighbor went out one day and suddenly looked like a different person. Some said they saw the cemetery gates open at midnight, and people who had been buried in the day walk right out of the graveyard at night. All kinds of stories like these, frightening and bizarre, came both day and night. At the time, the most ominous thing in the city was the Abyssal Trench Project, so people threw all these abnormal signs onto that Project. And then… they began to throw them onto the Queen of Frostholm as well.”

“People who were buried in the cemetery calmly walked out,” Agatha repeated. She frowned as she listened, as if it reminded her of the present. “And lights appearing in empty houses, this… this sounds…”

“It sounds a lot like that forged corpse in Cemetery No. 3, and the room you saw at 42 Fireplace Street, doesn’t it?” the old bishop said slowly. “But unlike back then, you have clear evidence now. You even collected evidence that might be elements. Back then, the city had only rumors. Every day someone came to tell me about some eerie thing they had met, but the Guardians ran all over the place and always came up empty.”

“Always came up empty?” Agatha asked.

“Yes. When residents filed a report, of course we had to send people to investigate. Even fifty years ago, we already had strict procedures like that. I sent many people to look into those horror stories. The Gatekeeper of the Great Cathedral even went to investigate in person, like you do now. But we never found anything. Aside from the citizens being nervous, the city?state itself was actually running as normal. In contrast, the test site of the Abyssal Trench Project was being fully sealed off step by step. All the terrible things were happening inside that sealed zone.

“As for what exactly happened there… you must have seen it in the archives. replicant Submersibles that kept appearing. Unregistered strangers coming and going. Explorers who died in the Deep Sea.”

Agatha fell silent for a moment. Her thoughts raced. For some reason, she felt a trace of wrongness in the old bishop’s story, something… off that no one had noticed for half a century.

“So you mean that even though the Abyssal Trench Project caused panic back then, in fact all the Anomaly events were limited to the test site. The city?state itself kept running as usual. People were under great mental pressure, and the city had trouble because of the Queen’s extreme decrees,

and people kept reporting Anomaly events. But from the point of view of supernatural power, the ‘corruption’ from the Deep Sea never really crossed the cordon around the test site?”

“…At least that is how it is in my memory,” the old bishop nodded lightly, then shifted his tone. “Of course, even so, I am not trying to defend the Queen of Frostholm. Even if the city really did stay normal, her Abyssal Trench Project had already stretched Frostholm’s economy and everyone’s nerves to the breaking point. Even if the Abyssal Trench Project had stayed under her control and had never gone into a runaway state, that re… uprising was still bound to happen.”

But Agatha seemed not to care about what the old bishop said at the end. She only thought for a bit, then shook her head: “Let us focus on what is in front of us, Bishop Ivan. About the situation in the city right now, and this denunciation letter in my hand, I want to know what you think.”

“You found traces of Annihilators in the city and evidence that they were pushing things from behind. That is actually a good thing. When supernatural corruption breaks out, the most frightening thing is not finding the enemy, but not finding any enemy at all.”

Bishop Ivan spoke slowly, then lifted the letter in his hand.

“This denunciation letter you brought also mentions that. It suspects that the Annihilators in Frostholm used some secret ritual to contact the power of the Deep Sea, causing Deep Sea corruption to spill directly into the city? state. So we should find the place where those cultists held their ritual.”

Agatha’s gaze met the one eye showing from under the old bishop’s bandages: “Do you think… this ‘Visitor’ who wrote the denunciation letter can be trusted?”

“At least every matter mentioned in the denunciation letter now has some evidence behind it. Even the parts that we cannot yet prove make sense logically,” Bishop Ivan nodded. “Of course, I cannot say for sure whether the being who wrote the letter can be trusted. A higher supernatural’s moods and view of the mortal world are not the same as those of Mortals. We can never deal with Them by using human emotional logic.

“All I can say is this: when They happen to act neutral or friendly for the moment, we can work with Them or even actively cooperate. But when They suddenly feel this is boring and decide to turn on us, we should not feel doubt or surprise. Remember that in this world, the only higher supernatural beings we can truly trust and give our loyalty to are the Four Gods. Everything else is neither enemy nor ally.”

The old bishop’s words held the wisdom of half a century. Even though their ranks were equal, Agatha lowered her head slightly in respect.

“Next time that Visitor appears, I will try to approach Them and see what Their attitude is.”

“That would be best,” Bishop Ivan said with a nod.

Agatha thought for a moment, then looked again at the letter in the old bishop’s hand.

“Then for now, we only have one last hard riddle left.”

Following her gaze, Bishop Ivan’s eyes also fell on the last part of the denunciation letter.

The rest of the letter was easy enough to understand, but that last section was different. Neither the cemetery warden who had first received it, nor Agatha and Bishop Ivan now, could grasp its deeper meaning.

The two people who spoke for the Church’s highest will in the city?state leaned together. Three eyes showing from under the bandages stared hard at

the end of the letter.

That indescribable, mysterious Visitor had left a puzzle in Their secret letter.

“…What do these numbers even mean?” Bishop Ivan asked, hesitating.

Agatha slowly shook her head: “I don’t understand it either.”

“…Maybe we can ask a Diviner to work it out, or invite experts in mathematics and occult studies to calculate it together. It might be a Secret Cipher pointing to the city?state’s future.”

“Makes sense.”

…

On the edge of the Upper City, at No. 44 Oak Street beside Fireplace Street, Duncan stood at the narrow window at the end of the second?floor corridor, looking out at the veil of night as it slowly came down.

After a long time, he suddenly turned his head and looked at Vanna, who was spacing out beside him: “Do you think they have sent the payment by now?”

Vanna snapped out of her daze, completely confused: “Huh… what?”

“Go to the bank for me tomorrow and see if they have sent the money,” Duncan said with a serious face. “I left an anonymous account in that denunciation letter. I use it just to collect whistleblower bounties.”

Vanna stared at him: “…Huh?”

Chapter 350: Sea Mist Surrounds the City

After nightfall, small snowflakes began to fall again, drifting through the air. In the hazy, fog-like darkness, the cold light of the World's Wound was mostly covered by clouds. Only a few patches of its chaotic glow seeped through the gaps. Street gas lamps lit up one after another along roads and alleys, shining on the snowflakes in midair and giving the city a quiet mood very different from Pland.

Vanna stood at the narrow window and stared at the night outside for a while. Then she sighed and said: "I'm sure they didn't send the money… and by now they have probably gathered a group of experts to crack the 'secret cipher' you left in that letter."

Duncan turned his head: "Is it really that serious?"

Vanna looked at her temporary boss with a very serious face: "…Did you explain in the letter what that string of numbers was for?"

"No, but isn't that the standard format for a denunciation letter?" Duncan answered with full confidence. "You just attach the account number at the end of the denunciation letter and City Hall will transfer the money. That's how it works in Pland. And I've heard many places don't put any special note in front of the account number, to make it sound more subtle and reserved—I thought I should be a bit reserved too."

Vanna stared at Duncan for a long time. In the end she could not help letting out another sigh: "Ah…"

Duncan thought for a moment. At this point he actually had a bit of self-awareness, so his tone became a little awkward: “I guess… it is kind of hard for them to understand?”

“It’s good that you understand that,” Vanna said with tired patience.

Duncan lowered his head and thought more carefully: “…It’s not a good idea to send a second letter now, is it?”

“You… should put your hopes on them figuring out what that denunciation letter was for as soon as possible,” Vanna said, rubbing her brow. She felt that she had once again discovered a surprising side of Captain Duncan. This powerful and terrifying captain… actually had such a clear and funny personality.

Duncan did not care what Vanna was thinking. He only asked, as if casually: “You took Annie home today. How is everything at her place?”

Vanna nodded at once: “Everything at Annie’s home was normal. There were no signs of supernatural manifestations or corruption. We also found no trace of Annihilators nearby. None of the neighbors looked suspicious. Madam Belloni… our current landlady… also seems like a…”

“Stop, stop,” Duncan quickly raised a hand before she finished. “I’m asking about her home life, her living situation. I’m not asking you to report along the full heretic investigation procedure. Control your occupational disease.”

Vanna froze for a second, then realized what she was doing and coughed twice: “Ahem, sorry, that’s… my work habit. Everything is fine over there. I only stayed for a short while and talked with Madam Belloni a little, but it was enough to judge the basics. After all, six years have passed. She and her daughter have already walked out of the shadows of that year.

“Now Annie goes to a public school in the city-state. Madam Belloni makes money by renting rooms and also has some clerical work, enough to support

the family. Besides, they are the family of a ship captain. Frostholm's authority does give support to such bereaved families, just like in other city-states. Overall… you don't need to worry about them."

Duncan listened quietly and nodded.

Vanna hesitated for a moment, then finally could not hold back: "You don't mind Annie talking about what's happening here… is that really okay? It might not be long before that cemetery warden knows you're living openly in the city. Then the matter will be reported to the Cathedral right away. The Gatekeeper and the Bishop will both be alerted."

"And then?" Duncan turned his head and asked in a calm voice.

"Then… there will be some trouble," Vanna said. Under Duncan's divine gaze, her tone suddenly lost some confidence. "The intervention of the city-state's authority might…"

"How exactly would they intervene?" Duncan asked with a smile. "Send a squad of Guardians to arrest us? Or have that Gatekeeper come talk to me personally? And what would I care about them? Am I afraid of exposing my whereabouts? Or am I afraid of hostile actions from the authority?"

As he spoke, Duncan spread his hands.

"I didn't bring the Vanished over, did I?"

Vanna opened her mouth. She felt something was very wrong about all this, but she really could not think of how to respond to such a calm stream of words from the captain. After holding it in for a long time, she only managed one line: "Why do I feel like you just think this might be fun?"

"Yes."

Vanna: "…"

Duncan chuckled and turned his gaze back to the night outside the window. He did not care about the wonderful expression that flashed across the inquisitor's face. After enjoying the night view in silence for a few minutes, he suddenly said: "Vanna, I'm starting to feel you are less and less like an inquisitor—under normal circumstances, when someone mentions the Church and the authority of a city-state, shouldn't your first reaction be 'reliable allies'?"

Vanna's mouth clearly twitched. A thousand words seemed to rise in her heart, but in the end not a single one came out.

At the same time, outside the city-state of Frostholm, out on the vast Boundless Sea shrouded by the veil of night, a huge fleet was slowly reducing speed and patrolling at low speed amid cold frozen mist and encircling floes.

The proud steel bow of the Sea Mist rose out of the darkness. Her navigation lights cast a glow along one side of the hull. More lights spilled down from that same side, lighting up the black sea surface below. In the rippling waves, faint reflections could be seen rising and falling.

They were fragments of drifting ice.

On the Frost Sea, every captain had heard a saying—

When thin mist suddenly appears, when ice floes emerge from the fog and slowly lock your ship in like chains, then be ready. The Sea Mist has arrived.

The Sea Mist had arrived now. The entire Sea Mist fleet had arrived.

Tyrian stood high on the bridge and looked into the distance through the wide windows.

From this distance, there was no way to see the city-state of Frostholm itself. But in the dark background, he could still see a faint glow floating in

that direction. That was where the city lay.

In truth, the Sea Mist fleet was heading toward Dagger Island, and Tyrian had no plan at all to set foot on Frostholm's main island. But for the people of Frostholm, who had lived under tension for half a century, there was no difference. As long as the flag of the "steel Vice Admiral" appeared on the nearby sea, it was enough to rob them of sleep and peace.

He could almost picture the chaos among Frostholm's garrison troops right now.

Footsteps came from the side. First Mate Aiden walked up next to Tyrian. The rough-faced, bald giant looked very pleased: "Captain, the Sea Crow and the Fjord have left the formation with their escort vessels. They should reach their planned positions in twelve hours and lock down the routes. The Sea Mist herself has lifted the blackout—those Frostholm folks can forget about getting a good night's sleep."

Tyrian nodded with a slight smile and let his eyes sweep over the sea around the Sea Mist.

In the darkness, the whole Boundless Sea was silent. Only the Sea Mist, with her blackout lifted, floated there, as eye-catching as a gas lamp in the night.

Normally, warships on night missions had to keep a strict light blackout. Unnecessary lighting could expose their position and also make it easier to confuse friendly light-signals.

But the Sea Mist simply showed herself to the world, bright and open, like a provocation aimed straight at Frostholm.

Tyrian was not worried at all that this would push Frostholm's City Navy into rash action, nor was he afraid of some "accidental discharge" starting a battle.

In this world, aside from the Vanished, no one could beat the “living ship” Sea Mist in a night battle. And on the other hand… if Frostholm’s navy was foolish enough to attack today, the six other warships hidden around the Sea Mist would immediately teach them a lesson.

Of course, Tyrian’s showy behavior was not only about venting or taunting Frostholm. His more important goal was to carry out the task his father had given him—

Make the city-state of Frostholm nervous. The more nervous the better. It would be best if they closed off the whole main island and blocked all routes in and out.

From what he had observed so far, that goal had already been reached. Frostholm’s garrison navy had sealed the Harbor and sent out signals to neighboring city-states, asking them to suspend shipping.

Everything was going just as his father had planned.

At that moment, a voice came from a copper tube nearby. Aiden walked over and spoke a few words with the post on the other end, then came back to Tyrian with a smile: “Captain, looks like the Frostholm people can’t sit still—there’s a small boat on the sea nearby.”

Tyrian raised an eyebrow: “A small boat?”

“Yes. It doesn’t seem to have any weapons, and it’s showing a signal lamp with three yellow and one white light. It looks like they’re afraid of causing any misunderstanding,” Aiden said. “The boat is carefully staying outside the range of our searchlights. It seems they want to observe us without making contact or showing hostility.”

“Observation… at least they still have some self-control,” Tyrian said with a shrug. “Let them watch. If they come too close, fire a warning shot.”

“Yes, Captain.” Aiden accepted the order, but before he turned away, Tyrian suddenly called out: “Wait.”

“Do you have other orders?”

“Send them a light-signal,” Tyrian said.

“A light-signal?” Aiden was startled. “What message?”

Tyrian’s lips curled up. The Pirate Lord who had a fierce reputation across the Frost Sea now wore a playful, mischievous smile: “Message? What message—just flash at random.”

Aiden: “…Huh?”

“Let the signalman flash whatever he wants,” Tyrian said happily, rubbing his chin. “Give Frostholm’s expert advisers a small ‘problem of the century’.”

A wide grin quickly spread across Aiden’s face. Even his bald head seemed to shine.

“Yes, Captain!”

Chapter 351: Sealed City

For the protectors of Frostholm, this night was doomed to be sleepless.

The dark clouds over Dagger Island were still coiling overhead. The strange, returned wreck of the Sea Swallow was still moving back and forth on the water outside the Harbor. And right at this critical moment, the Sea Mist fleet, wrapped in countless dreadful legends, had come to the city-state's doorstep.

The Undying fleet bearing the curse had already finished gathering. It stayed in silence at the edge of the coastal waters. No one knew why they had come. No one knew what they would do next.

Harbor Defense Commander Lister had slept for less than an hour around midnight before he once again appeared in his command office. There he met several other commanders with tight faces and a confidential secretary who had just hurried over from City Hall.

The secretary, a man in a fitted blue coat and gold-rimmed glasses who looked barely over thirty, stood up at once when he saw Lister. Beads of sweat glistened on his forehead: "Colonel, the Governor wants the newest and most accurate information—does the Sea Mist fleet have any chance of launching an attack?"

"If that is all the Governor wants to know, then yes. There has been such a chance every single day for the past half century," Lister said. He took out a vial of stimulant essence and relied on the sharp scent to push back his fatigue, then glanced at the confidential secretary. "The Sea Mist fleet did

not appear today for the first time. It has always been there. Frostholm and that ‘steel Vice Admiral’ have never had a peace treaty.”

The general commander was clearly in a bad mood. The secretary realized at once that his question was pointless and quickly changed his wording: “How prepared are we?”

“All coastal guns are in battle configuration. The fleet under General Galton is forming an interception line to the north and northwest of the Sea Mist fleet. They have plenty of fuel and full magazines. Although we just lost a brave Rear Admiral in the Sea Swallow incident, the Frostholm navy is still fully prepared to defend the city-state,” Lister said solemnly. “For more detailed information, my superiors should already have reported to City Hall.”

As he spoke, he looked past the secretary at a few subordinates standing not far away: “What is the situation on the Sea Mist fleet’s side now? Any anomalous moves?”

One commander stood up at once: “Yes, Commander. Something is off. You should take a look at this.”

Hearing this, Lister’s brow furrowed. He walked quickly to the long table in the middle of the room and stopped before a report that had only just been delivered.

“What is this?”

The harbor commander stared in confusion at the sheet full of symbols and marks.

“It’s a light-signal,” the subordinate commander said. “A light-signal from the Sea Mist.”

Lister’s expression went a bit blank. The stimulant essence seemed to stop working for a moment. He looked at the dizzying rows of pause marks and

messy notes, and his head actually began to spin. After a long while, he muttered: “What on earth… Is the Sea Mist fleet using some very new light-signal system? Or some kind of classical code?”

He suddenly looked up at his subordinate: “Where is the Military Advisor?”

“They’re in the next room studying this, along with several signal experts and cipher experts we just called in. A few scholars who study classical naval history and the Undying phenomenon are also on their way.”

Lister pressed his lips together, stared at the jumble of symbols for a few seconds, then lifted his head and looked at the worried secretary.

“No one is sleeping tonight.”

“I agree, Colonel,” the secretary said softly.

…

Duncan had slept very well the previous night.

Most of the time, his main body did not really need sleep, but proper rest still helped him keep his energy up and eased the strain of controlling several bodies at once—even if that strain was not much for him.

He simply liked to keep a normal schedule, like an ordinary human.

The snow outside the window had stopped, at least for the moment. No one knew how long the clear sky would last. It stretched over the entire city. Vision 001 was slowly climbing from the edge of the city toward the top of the sky. Along the rim of the brilliant Sun Wheel, a faint golden sheen from twin runes shone with great radiance.

That missing little section of the rune ring was still there, and still clearly visible to the naked eye.

Duncan stood at the window and stared at the chipped Sun Wheel and rune ring for a few seconds. Then he pulled his gaze back and rolled his shoulders.

He went down to the first floor.

Alice had already made breakfast. Simple toast, fried eggs, and vegetable wraps were not exactly a feast, but from them you could tell the doll's cooking skills were slowly getting better. Vanna and Morris were sitting at the table eating. When they saw Duncan come down, they both stood up.

"Just eat. Don't mind me," Duncan said, waving a hand.

The breakfast looked good, but this body could not enjoy it.

Though all his bodies were "temporary shells," the one he used in Pland's antique shop was very different from this one in Frostholm. The Pland body had also been taken over after death, but because it had only minor damage and he took it over in time, it now was almost no different from a living person.

But the body he used in Frostholm had already lost most of its inner functions.

It was more like a corpse driven by some mysterious power. In nature, it was closer to a real corpse than the Undying under Tyrian's command.

Duncan himself could not explain the principles behind it, but this world had far too many strange things. He had long since stopped worrying.

Weird was fine. He was the biggest "weird" thing in this world anyway.

"There's a fresh paper next to the sofa," Morris said at the table. "You might want to take a look. There's news you'll be interested in."

"Oh?" Duncan walked to the sofa and saw the morning paper that had just been delivered. It still smelled slightly of ink. The sheets were stacked

neatly. He picked them up, sat down on the sofa, opened the paper, and quickly found the article Morris had mentioned.

Alice came over with a clacking sound, stuck her head over the back of the sofa, and peered at the paper in Duncan's hands with curiosity: "What does the headline sa—"

Click.

A round head fell onto Duncan's newspaper and then rolled down onto his arm.

The head flipped over. Alice lay on her back, face up, looking straight at Duncan. She blinked innocently: "Hel… hel… help…"

"Can you please try to learn something?" Duncan sighed and picked up Alice's head with almost resigned skill. He straightened the golden wig tied down with a cord and the silver hair underneath, then pressed the pretty head back onto the custom-built doll body her "Brother" had made. "Even Dog can read the paper now, and you can't even understand the headline?"

Alice hurried to hold her head steady and muttered in embarrassment: "It's just four or five words I don't know…"

"There are eight words in the headline," Duncan said, glaring at her.

The illiterate doll: "…Hehe."

"It's a warning notice from City Hall," Duncan sighed. He felt that arguing seriously with this silly girl was nothing but exhausting, so he pointed at the words on the paper and read them one by one for Alice. "Notice to citizens, reduce going out—then the article tells Frostholm residents not to go near the coast in the near future. They should avoid gathering on public roads, be ready at all times to cooperate with inspections by constables or Guardians, and the curfew level has been raised. Now, except for Church staff and

people who hold special night work permits, no one is allowed to leave their home at night."

Alice walked around the sofa and sat down next to Duncan. She leaned over to stare at the words on the page. Her head turned wherever his finger moved. After reading the whole thing once, she finally lifted her head in confusion: "What does it mean?"

"It means Tyrian has put on enough pressure," Duncan said calmly. "Next, unless something unexpected happens, Frostholm's external traffic will be sealed. That way we don't have to worry about the city's corruption leaking out. The Annihilators hiding here will no longer be able to contact the outside world.

"On the other hand, the denunciation letter I sent seems to have stirred up the Church. A higher curfew level and strict travel bans mean tighter heretic screening. More Annihilators will slip up."

"Then… is the whole thing solved?" Alice asked, eyes wide with surprise. "Will all the bad people be caught?"

"How could it be that simple?" Duncan shrugged. "Catching a few Annihilators is only the beginning. As more of them are caught, their method of connecting with the Deep Sea might be exposed. That's when the real problem will finally be dug out."

As he spoke, he folded the newspaper and set it aside.

He had skimmed the remaining articles. There was nothing else worth much attention.

"Then… what are we going to do next?" Alice asked.

"Since Frostholm's authority is busy, we should go out and move around too," Duncan said, standing up and looking toward the dining room. "After

breakfast, we'll go out—we're going to say hello to an 'informant' working under Tyrian."

Chapter 352: Informant and the Underground Waterway

After two days of continuous snowfall, a brief spell of clear weather seemed to sweep away the gloom hanging over the city-state, and Frostholm woke once more as it always did. Snowplows and de-icing machines started clearing the snow from the main roads. The old high-pressure gas pipes and power grid once again passed their test, and the factories and public transit systems started running again.

All kinds of traffic and machine noises swelled with the sunrise.

However, beneath this slowly awakening surface, a strange and tense atmosphere was spreading through the city. Even the ordinary people were finally noticing the change in the air.

It began with the news in the papers. The emergency control notices suddenly issued by City Hall made those with sharper noses sense something was wrong. Then came all kinds of rumors from the waterfront districts, stories of the Sea Mist Fleet appearing near the city-state. The news spread quickly. Soon, all sorts of true and false reports were being traded on every street corner.

Recently, the city’s security forces had been redeployed again and again. Guardian units were gathering around several cemeteries. Grim stories were coming out of certain neighborhoods. Mixed into all this were the strange tales that had been circulating in the city for a month already, about the

return of The dead. All these unsettling things seemed to suddenly pile together and begin to quietly spread through the city.

On the Boundless Sea, city-states were like crowded pigeon coops. Vast stretches of water lay between one city and the next, but between one person and another they were almost within arm’s reach. There was nothing harder than sending news from one city-state to another, and nothing easier than spreading news inside a city-state.

Even so, life still had to go on. The worrying rumors only spread through the streets and alleys, while the citizens still went out and went to work as usual. At most, they talked a little about the city’s strange mood while squeezing onto the bus or chatting in a tavern. A bit of pressure was not enough to disrupt the running of a city-state.

In the end, the people of this world were already used to living under a shadow. To them, odd and uncanny things happening in the city were normal. cultist sabotage and the occasional veil of night freaks crawling out from somewhere were just part of everyday life. A city that stayed peaceful and quiet even after nightfall was what would seem abnormal to them.

At the junction of Cemetery No. 4 and Oak Street, a small tavern named the Golden Flute was growing lively.

Most of the citizens heading from the district to the factories for work in the morning would pass that corner. As a cheap, public-facing tavern, the Golden Flute was the best place to stop before going on shift. It did not only serve alcohol, it also offered decent coffee and simple breakfasts, perfect for filling the stomach and driving away the cold. Chatting with a few people over breakfast here counted as a bit of leisure before the tense and busy workday began.

The waiters moved busily between the round tables. The shop assistant worked behind the bar, greeting guests. Warm yellow light fell from the

ceiling and drove back the winter chill. A middle-aged man with a long, thin face and dry, yellowish hair sat in a chair not far behind the bar, idly turning the pages of a newspaper while watching the room out of the corner of his eye.

The tavern was a bit noisy. Rough jokes and unrestrained curses broke out from time to time. Most of the people eating here were not “upper-class citizens” by any standard. They were mostly ordinary people heading from the Lower City to work in the industrial ring. They gathered here and used the little time at breakfast to talk about what was happening in the Lower City or in the factory districts, or to give their own crude opinions on the city’s recent changes.

Their views were shallow and dull for the most part. No one important cared what these people thought of the city.

As long as they did not start a fight in the shop, everything was fine.

The middle-aged shopkeeper with the sallow hair turned the newspaper to the next page and yawned in boredom.

Then he felt the room go a little quieter around him. A moment later, it seemed as if something was blocking the light from above.

The shopkeeper looked up and saw a tall figure standing in front of him.

The newcomer wore a pitch-black coat that made one think of the coming of the veil of night. A high collar covered most of his face. A wide-brimmed hat pressed down like a dark cloud, shutting out all prying gazes from the outside world. In the few gaps between hat and collar, the only thing visible was layer upon layer of bandages.

A stern gaze hid under the low shadow of that hat.

An oppressive pressure rolled off him, something you could feel just from looking. The middle-aged shopkeeper’s heart seemed to miss a beat almost

at once. Panic rose in his eyes before he could stop it. His first reaction was to mistake the man for clergy from the Death sect. Those devout priests loved this kind of “bandage outfit,” which always felt excessive to ordinary people. But then he noticed the man in black was not wearing the Church’s Triangular Sigil, nor was he carrying the special Gatekeeper’s cane issued to Guardians.

After a brief moment of panic, the shopkeeper forced himself to calm down. He saw that three more people stood behind the tall figure: a young lady almost as tall as he was, a kindly looking old man, and a blonde woman with a veil over her face, whose bearing was noble and mysterious. Thoughts spun quickly in the shopkeeper’s mind.

These guests were here for him. Judging by their outfits, they were certainly not harmless. The heavy pressure they carried made even him feel short of breath. Were they secret constables from the central districts? Or people sent by some other power out on the Frost Sea? Why had they come to him? To threaten him, recruit him, or… ask for a favor?

He put the newspaper down beside him, stood up calmly, and looked up at the man in black: “Who are you looking for?”

“Mr. Nemo Wilkins,” Duncan said. He had noticed the panic and tension in the middle-aged man’s eyes. It was clearly the result of being crushed by his aura, and that was on purpose. Duncan was watching the man’s reactions. The most genuine flashes of emotion that surfaced under pressure helped him judge whether someone had been affected by cognitive interference or memory correction. “Is that your name?”

“Everyone here knows my name,” Nemo Wilkins said with a nod. He waved lightly at the shop assistant nearby. “You’re here for me then? But I’m only an honest, law-abiding businessman…”

“Recently the sea has been foggy, and the wind has been very cold,” Duncan said slowly as he reached into his coat and took out the city map prepared by Tyrian himself. “We need a good strong drink to warm our stomachs—preferably something that could even warm a dead man’s guts.”

At the moment he heard the phrase “the sea has been foggy, and the wind has been very cold,” Nemo’s breathing changed, just slightly. His gaze then fell on the city map.

This “shopkeeper” hid his emotions and the changes in his eyes extremely well. In fact, aside from that tiny moment when his breathing and heartbeat shifted, it was impossible to see anything odd about him from the outside. But even such a small reaction did not escape Vanna’s eyes.

“Looks like he’s the one,” Vanna said softly.

Duncan nodded slightly and put the folded map away. “Do you have any seats upstairs?”

“The seats upstairs are full,” Nemo said, shaking his head. “Come with me.”

With that, he stepped out from behind the counter and led his uninvited guests toward a door beside the stairs.

The tavern was still full of voices. Even if someone noticed the movement by the bar, no one paid enough attention to figure out what was going on.

Duncan and the others followed behind Nemo the shopkeeper. They passed through a rather low wooden door and entered a passage that seemed to lead to the storage room at the back of the shop. Halfway along, they turned through another door and started down a sloping ramp. They walked downhill for quite a long distance. Only when it felt as if they had already gone far beyond the area under the tavern did they stop in front of a dark wooden door.

“This place is really deep,” Morris muttered.

“Caution never hurts. This city doesn’t welcome anyone connected to the Sea Mist Fleet,” Nemo Wilkins said as he walked toward the door. “Enemies are everywhere—even now, half a century later.”

“How did you dig out a place like this right under The authority’s nose?” Vanna’s attention was different from the others’. As an Inquisitor, she cared more about how a “gray middleman” hid inside a city-state. “To dig such a long tunnel under a tavern, where did you take all the stone and dirt? And how did you hide the noise from the digging?”

Nemo Wilkins turned his head slightly and glanced at the towering white-haired lady, his tone carrying a hint of amusement: “Simple—there was no need to dig. This was already part of Frostholm’s underground waterway.”

As he finished speaking, the dark door swung open. With a creak and groan, the glow of gas lamps shone into Duncan’s eyes.

Along with the light came the faint, distant sound of running water from somewhere unknown.

Duncan looked past the open door and saw a particularly wide “hall.” It seemed to be the junction of old sewers. Corridors stretched away into the darkness in the distance. Tables, chairs, beds, and shelves had been set up in the corners of the hall. It even looked livable.

A fair number of people could be stationed here.

—

Chapter 353: The Second Waterway

“This is a safe place. At least for the past fifty years, the Frostholm authorities have never known that such a secret lies beneath their feet,” Nemo Wilkins said as he stepped into the hideout buried deep underground. He turned to Duncan and the others as they followed him in, his tone plainly proud. “These old sewers crisscross beneath the city. Most sections have already been abandoned, so they’re dry and safe. Some branches lead up to the higher-level pipe systems, but all the connecting points are secure. Even if one or two of them are discovered, City Hall cannot search the entire underground structure—they simply don’t have the manpower.”

As he spoke, the “tavern boss” walked over to a nearby concrete wall and turned a valve on one of the pipes. A faint hiss of gas came from somewhere far off. More gas lamps lit up at once, and the lamps that had already been burning grew brighter.

“In fact, City Hall is already doing pretty well just keeping the city’s basic functions running,” he went on, turning back around with a crooked grin. His long, thin face carried a trace of mockery. “As for what was hidden in the sewers half a century ago… only the old Artificers who once served Frostholm’s queen could really say.”

“…This is a facility left from the Queen’s era?!” Vanna immediately picked up on the truth in his words. Her eyes widened slightly in surprise. “These underground waterways… how did you manage to hide them?”

Nemo shrugged. “I wasn’t around for the chaos fifty years ago, but my grandfather talked my ear off about it all his life. He told me that the Frostholm queen once built a vast underground system beneath the entire city-state. At first it was meant to ease the pressure of land use and lay the groundwork for the city’s long-term growth. These underground structures included the most advanced underground waterways in the world at the time, power conduits, an electrical grid, and a whole transport system. The ‘sewer’ you see here is the deepest part of it. Strictly speaking, it was originally named the ‘Second Waterway,’ because above it there was a First Waterway—that’s the sewer system Frostholm still uses today.

“When the Great Uprising broke out, the city didn’t fall immediately. Even though the Rebels later claimed they ‘completely destroyed the mad Queen’s Guard Corps in a very short time,’ the truth was different. For a full seventy-two hours after the queen’s palace—now the civic center—was taken, the fighting continued. The loyalists who stayed in the city retreated from the surface into the underground. The crisscrossing subway stations and power conduit networks were full of people killing each other.

“The Rebels who had broken into the city center announced victory. The newspapers ran stories about the change of regime. citizens hid at home, uneasy and afraid. The subway stations were sealed. People lay on the ground near pipe shafts, listening to all kinds of unsettling sounds rising from the deep.

“All of this lasted until the day of the execution. The roar of the collapsing sea cliff shook the whole city and finally ended the last resistance underground.

“After that, the Queen’s Guard Corps blew up all the vertical shafts leading down to the Second Waterway and shut the gates that connected it to the First Waterway. Later there were more small skirmishes and intentional

collapses. In the end, the entire Second Waterway was completely cut off from the upper levels."

As he spoke, Nemo Wilkins lifted his head to look at the heavy dome overhead. His gaze seemed to pass through layers of steel, concrete, and stone to sweep across the busy streets of the city-state above.

"In truth, the new government set up by the Rebels wasn't completely ignorant of these sewers," he said. "They knew about Frostholm's underground world. But so what? Knowing it exists is one thing. Doing something about it is another.

"The sea cliff collapsed. The city suffered heavy damage. After the civil war, it took Frostholm decades to recover. Boiling Gold became the city's only remaining economic pillar. The 'number one city-state on the Frost Sea' was reduced to a few glorious pages in history books. Even today, the city still relies on the pipe system the Queen left behind.

"Under those conditions, who had the resources to search the huge network deep under the city? The cost of reopening the shafts and refurbishing the Second Waterway was unacceptable for the new government. And with Frostholm's population and urban footprint both reduced after the war, the First Waterway alone was enough."

"If it works, just make do," Vanna murmured without thinking, recalling something Morris had said not long ago.

"Exactly. If it's enough, you make do. This city is already full of wounds. It really can't take another big shake-up," Nemo said with a smile. "Besides, for a city this big, a bit of 'moss' growing deep in the sewers isn't such a big problem. Heretic cults, spawns of darkness, veil of shadows, Anomaly objects from the runaway state… there are plenty of things hiding in the gutters. Any one of them is more worth the authority's and the Church's headaches than we are."

Duncan had barely spoken, just quietly listening to this “Informant” ramble on. Now he finally broke his silence: “Such a huge underground facility, and from what I see, it still has gas and power. There’s no way you’re maintaining all this on your own, right?”

“Of course not,” Nemo Wilkins said with a laugh. “We have a few people, scattered all over the city. Some are even in certain departments of City Hall. Most of them are descendants of the Queen’s Guard Corps, like me. A few others passed General Tyrian’s tests and were confirmed as loyal, trustworthy brothers and sisters. But they’re not suitable for showing themselves in public.”

“…Tyrian told me he’d planted a few ‘informants’ in Frostholm. That was modest of him,” Duncan said, unable to stop himself from shaking his head. “That kid has buried quite a lot of strength here…”

Nemo heard the way Duncan referred to Tyrian as “that kid.” His expression froze for a moment, but he did not say anything.

While they talked, Morris was carefully studying the underground world around them. His gaze moved over the towering dome and the abandoned pipes crossing high overhead, then to the many valves and side branches that had clearly been installed later on the nearby walls. After a while, he suddenly asked: “Do you still control the entire Second Waterway?”

“Strictly speaking, only a small part of it,” Nemo said with a regretful shake of his head. “I’d love to say the whole underground kingdom is under our command, but we simply don’t have enough people, and the scale of the Second Waterway is beyond imagination. Right now, we control only about one fifth of the abandoned sewers. The rest are either cut off and unusable because of collapses, covered in toxic sewage, or corrupted by dangerous forces that make them hard to enter.”

“corrupted by dangerous forces?” Vanna’s brow furrowed at once. Her professional instincts started pounding.

“Sometimes, illegal supernatural who are being hunted flee into the sewers,” Nemo said. “If they die down here, they can cause large-scale corruption. But more often, it’s the darkness itself breeding monsters. This is, after all, a vast underground world. The gas we secretly draw from the upper pipe network is nowhere near enough to light the entire Second Waterway. When the light isn’t enough… some places fall into darkness, and then they stay in darkness forever.”

Vanna stared, at a loss for words. For a moment she even felt short of breath.

Coming from prosperous Pland, and being one of the protectors of order in a city-state, she truly could not imagine a city actually allowing such a situation to exist. A large-scale underground facility left in darkness for years, to the point that it was already starting to breed shadows that could not be purified—this was acceptable?

Yet the facts before her showed that it did exist, and Frostholm had lived like this for half a century. Nothing “too serious” seemed to have happened.

“We can’t rule out the occasional unlucky mortal who wanders down here and simply vanishes, or that the Guardians’ casualty rate at night is higher than in other city-states,” Nemo added. “But people are used to it.”

He clearly saw the shock on Vanna’s face. He had already guessed that these visitors were outsiders and knew exactly what she was so surprised about.

“Every few years, they clear out a few dangerous spots in the First Waterway and the subway branches,” he went on. “From time to time they flood the underground with incense and Sacred Bone Ash. They raise the

Guardians' death benefits a little. They have the Gatekeepers run a few more patrols. Most ordinary people still live reasonably well… That already counts as a good situation."

He paused for a moment, then turned his head with a smile. "Believe me, most city-states aren't much better. They never have been, from ancient times to now."

Duncan and the others looked at one another, not sure what to say. After a brief and awkward silence, Vanna was the first to speak. She turned to Morris and asked: "What is your assessment?"

"No signs of cognitive interference. His thoughts and memories should be clear," Morris replied to Vanna. His gaze remained fixed on Nemo Wilkins. In the old scholar's eyes, a faint silver light slowly faded away.

Nemo blinked and showed a puzzled expression. "What are you talking about?"

Duncan turned his gaze on him, quietly fixing him with his gaze. "Mr. Nemo, congratulations. You have not been affected by cognitive interference."

Chapter 354: The Infiltrators

Nemo Wilkins suddenly felt a faint dizziness, as if some invisible force had brushed across his mind. It was as if he had just woken from a strange, shallow dream. In that late moment of alarm, he jerked his head up and looked, tense and wary, at the elderly Mr. who always wore a gentle expression and seemed cultured and harmless.

Morris gave this informant a friendly, polite smile.

But Nemo suddenly broke out in a cold sweat. Only now did he remember that from the moment they had entered the secret passage, the old man's gaze had almost never left him. A power that felt as if it were rifling through his mind and combing through his memories had been wrapped around his thoughts the whole time. He had been unconsciously answering every question these uninvited guests asked, and had almost exposed the situation at the other contact points in the city-state!

Even if these uninvited guests held Captain Tyrian's token and knew the passphrases, he still should not have been so careless! After all, these people had appeared out of nowhere today. By the rules, he should have tested them more.

The rapid changes on the informant's face did not escape Vanna's eyes. She stepped forward, her solemn expression carrying a touch of earnestness as she said: "Mr. Wilkins, relax. We are not enemies— The token and passphrases we carry do indeed come from Mr. Tyrian. We only ran some tests on you just now out of necessary security concerns."

“Tests… what tests?” Nemo stared at the people before him, full of wariness. “Who exactly are you people?”

“In short, we suspect that a large-scale Cognitive corruption has begun to spread through the city-state. This corruption makes people unknowingly form false memories, lose an accurate understanding of the Mortal Realm, and even become accomplices of heretics without realizing it. We cannot be sure whether the informants Mr. Tyrian left in the city are all still reliable, so we have to run tests,” Vanna explained seriously, then shifted the topic. “As for who we are… you did not receive any message from Mr. Tyrian?”

“The captain did not explain in detail. He only said you were a few people he could trust,” Nemo answered cautiously. “Forgive my doubts— He never made such baffling arrangements before.”

Morris thought for a moment, then understood and looked at Duncan: “Oh, then it might be because he did not have your explicit permission. He probably did not dare reveal who we are.”

Permission? Captain Tyrian did not dare reveal their identities?

Hearing Morris’s words, Nemo’s expression instantly turned a little strange. He instinctively looked at the bandage-wrapped, black-clad weirdo. Nemo clearly wanted to ask something, but did not know how to begin.

Duncan did not dwell on it. He only nodded lightly: “Since we have confirmed this informant is fine, there is no need to hide it.”

As he spoke, he looked at Nemo and pointed at himself: “I am Tyrian’s father.”

The Sea Mist covert agent named Nemo Wilkins froze for a few seconds. Then his thoughts seemed to scramble in some strange way, and he suddenly glared: “Do not insult the captain!”

Duncan: “……”

The air turned awkward for a moment. Vanna and Morris both could not help pressing their hands to their foreheads. Only Alice glanced left and right, as if she still had not caught up. She looked very serious as she said to the informant: “It is true.”

Nemo clearly still wanted to speak, but this time, before he could open his mouth, Morris stepped forward and patted his shoulder: “Young man, think it through before you talk— The great ‘Steel Vice Admiral’ Tyrian also has a father.”

Only then did Nemo Wilkins finally notice the subtle shift in the mood and catch up with the earlier conversation. At once he recalled the old tales about the Abnomar family, about Captain Tyrian’s family, about the Vanished, about that Restless Soul wandering Subspace. When he lifted his head to look at Duncan again, his eyes were clearly different.

“I came back from Subspace,” Duncan said, watching him, his voice calm. “I am here to help Tyrian deal with a bit of trouble.”

Nemo stared for a moment. His eyes rolled back, and he toppled over.

But Vanna seemed ready. Before the informant hit the ground, she grabbed his arm with one hand. With the other, she pulled out a whole bottle of Mind-Clearing Essence Oil, flicked off the stopper, and poured it straight into Nemo’s nostrils.

The informant practically shot straight up.

“Ah… ah… ah-choo! Ah-choo!” Nemo was fully awake now. His nose was full of the fierce smell of the ointment. He sneezed several times in place before it finally eased. With snot and tears running down his face, he lifted his head, sniffled, and said nervously: “I… I…”

“Sorry— I forgot ordinary people are not as tough as Guardians,” Vanna said, a little embarrassed as she hid the glass bottle in her hand. “But do not

worry. This stuff will not harm your body."

Nemo took a handkerchief from his pocket. As he wiped the tears and snot from his face, he forced himself to calm down. With eyes full of fear and hesitation, he looked at Duncan: "It… it is really you? Then… then what can I do for you…?"

"You are already working for me," Duncan waved his hand. "Do not be so tense. Just tell me more about Frostholm."

"Al… alright," Nemo nodded again and again, then sneezed a few more times before settling down. "What else would you like to ask?"

"Are you currently in contact with the other informants in the city?" Duncan asked. "How do you usually communicate? Do you gather in this sewer system, or use more hidden channels?"

"We seldom gather," Nemo said as he rubbed his nose. "It is mainly for safety— Many of our members have close ties with the Upper City, so they need to stay hidden. Most of the time, we trade information through various secret channels, like coded messages in newspapers, specific meeting spots, or by relying on 'couriers' for one-way contact.

"In fact, even we do not know how many of 'our own' there really are in the city. Most informants only know their direct superiors and subordinates, or a few 'fellows' in the same area. The full list is only in the hands of Captain Tyrian and Mr. Aiden. I count as the 'handler' for my tier, so I hold a few more names than most, but even so, it is no more than ten people…"

Listening to Nemo, Vanna could not help nodding slightly: "A very cautious and efficient way to stay hidden. Most cultists who play games with the Guardians are not this professional."

"After all, it is the result of Tyrian's work over half a century," Duncan said offhand at the side. Then he looked at Nemo again. "Are you the only one

stationed at this contact point?”

“There are two more,” Nemo nodded. “One has the nickname ‘Crow’. He should be patrolling the nearby tunnels right now. The other is an old man who spends most of his time in the abandoned pipe crew room. I do not even know his real name. We all call him ‘Old Ghost’.”

Duncan exchanged a look with Vanna and Morris.

Nemo Wilkins did not seem affected by any cognitive interference, but the same might not be true for the people around him.

“Let us go say hello too,” Duncan nodded. “Where is this pipe crew room?”

“Right over here,” Nemo said, raising his hand to point to the right side of the fork ahead. “It used to be the temporary rest area for the maintenance workers on the Second Waterway. I will take you.”

The informant strode ahead, and on the way he began to tell Duncan and the others about this “Old Ghost”.

“…He is already over seventy this year, almost the oldest among us. My grandfather used to work with him, back in the Queen’s era…

“Old Ghost’s head is not very clear, but when it comes to gas pipes and the connecting sections of the Second Waterway, he never makes mistakes. The extra gas line we added here was done by him and his crew. They secretly tapped a branch off the main line above. It had to be safe and also not be discovered. That is not the sort of job just anyone can handle…

“Old Ghost rarely goes up to the surface. He spends most of his time down here. Sometimes, after he drinks, he boasts to us about the old days. He says that decades ago he was the engineer for the Second Waterway, and the Queen even gave him a medal in person— But to be honest, very little of what he says is believable. I have seen that medal of his. It is just a piece of

iron with nothing on it. It is obvious he picked it up from some dark corner…

“Ah, most likely he breathed in too much toxic gas when they retreated into the Second Waterway back then— Did I tell you? Fifty years ago, when the last Queen’s Guard Corps pulled back, they sealed the Second Waterway. The vertical shaft collapsed, and some of the poisonous gas drifted down from above. A few Artificers loyal to the Queen rushed in to plug the leaks. Old Ghost seems to have been one of them. They say his mind has not been quite right since then.

“If he suddenly starts shouting about the Queen later, do not mind it… He does not mean anything by it.”

With Nemo Wilkins chattering the whole way, Duncan and the others soon walked past the fork and reached a rusty iron door near the sewer junction.

Nemo stepped forward, knocked on the door, called inside, and then pushed it open: “Old Ghost, we have guests.”

As soon as he finished speaking, a hoarse but very loud voice came from inside the room—

“Ah, the Queen has come to inspect!?”

Chapter 355: The Disturbance Deep in the Abandoned Waterway

As the old yet booming voice rang out, Duncan heard a series of clattering noises from the hut, as if someone had stood up in a hurry and bumped into a pile of junk. Then came approaching footsteps, and an old man appeared in the doorway. He was hunched over, with sparse white hair, a dull gray coat, and a face covered in deep wrinkles.

The man called “Old Ghost” stood inside his little administrator’s hut, bent at the waist. His somewhat cloudy eyes swept over the people outside. Duncan could not tell whether the old man had even seen them clearly before he lowered his head and muttered in a hurry: “The Queen has come to inspect… I did not even get ready… Those assistants are getting more and more unreliable, and the messengers too…”

“Old Ghost!” Nemo had to raise his voice to cut off the old man’s rambling. “The Queen is not here! The Queen is not coming back! We have guests today— They are important guests Captain Tyrian arranged. Stop muttering. They came to see you.”

As he spoke, Nemo turned his head, his face apologetic as he said to Duncan: “Sorry— As you can see, he is a bit unhinged. He often suddenly slips back into things from decades ago. But do not be fooled. The moment he deals with pipes and valves, he becomes clear-headed at once.”

“Clear-headed? I am clear-headed!” In the time it took to say that, Old Ghost’s eyes suddenly shifted, as if he had come to his senses. He looked

over Duncan and the others and muttered: “Guests. Strange faces can still make it down here… Did you check their tokens and passphrases?”

“We checked. Of course we checked,” Nemo said at once, sneaking a careful glance at Duncan. “They are honored guests. Just treat it as if… as if Captain Tyrian were here in person.”

“Oh, then come in. There is not much to see here anyway,” Old Ghost grumbled as he moved aside. “Just some old junk, if you do not mind it.”

Vanna turned to look at Morris. Morris kept his eyes fixed on Old Ghost.

A moment later, Morris shook his head and spoke very softly: “Hard to judge— His mind is not very sound to begin with, and his memory keeps cutting in and out.”

Duncan heard Morris’s quiet report. His expression did not change. He simply followed the muttering old man inside and stepped into the abandoned staff rest room.

The room was not large. A single gas lamp lit it brightly. As expected, it was piled high with all sorts of things. Aside from a bed in the corner, everything in sight was sagging shelves and crates on the floor, stuffed full of mechanical parts, spare valve sets, and work tools.

Even a skilled acrobat would come out of here with serious injuries.

“So messy,” Alice muttered quietly as she looked at the chaos in the room. “I really want to tidy it up…”

“Ah, my deepest apologies!” Old Ghost, who had been moving through a pile of clutter, turned at once and bowed, bent low. “Your Majesty the Queen, I have been neglecting my duties lately. This place is a bit of a mess…”

Alice froze: “Huh?”

Duncan’s eyes also changed slightly. But just as he looked at Old Ghost, ready to say something, the old man suddenly grew hazy again. He straightened up while muttering to himself: “Strange, where did I put my kettle… How can guests come and not even get a sip of water…”

Duncan and the others looked at one another.

“You do not need to look for your kettle. Our guests only want to ask you a few things,” Nemo said at this point. “About the current state of the Second Waterway, and about yourself. They are here to investigate.”

“Investigate?” Old Ghost stopped at once and turned around, his expression suddenly grave. “General Tyrian still needs to investigate his own troops? Has there been a traitor? Is it in our sector? Or over in the central district? I knew they had been acting strange lately…”

“There is no traitor, but other infiltrators might be under threat from some kind of supernatural corruption,” Vanna stepped forward then, and almost tripped on the junk on the floor— For her height of one meter ninety, this cramped chaos was truly a challenge. “Have you been in touch with people from other sectors recently? Has anyone shown any Anomalies?”

“Anomalies? Not quite to that point. But the handler over in the central district keeps saying there are gurgling sounds in the abandoned pipes over there, as if someone is trying to bring the Second Waterway back online,” Old Ghost waved his hand. “You have seen the state of the Second Waterway. The things built in the Queen’s time are solid, but it has still been abandoned for so many years. There are many sections down there we simply cannot approach. Sometimes the underground river seeps into the cracks in the rock and brings strange noises with it. That is normal…”

The old man’s words kept drifting off topic, and Duncan had to speak to drag the conversation back: “This central district you mentioned… Is that the same area where the Boiling Gold mine is?”

“Boiling Gold? Ah, yes, Boiling Gold, all in that area— The Cathedral is there, the Queen’s palace is there, and the mine is there as well. That mine is deep, several hundred meters at least,” Old Ghost sat down on his bed. As he talked, he suddenly slapped his leg. “Ah, right. The sounds must be coming from one of the levels of the mine. The Second Waterway runs quite close to it there… I told you, the handler in that sector is just too nervous, always jumpy…”

The old man started muttering to himself again, but this time Duncan did not interrupt. He had already sunk into thought.

He recalled how he had first come to Frostholm, and the first body he had used here— A worker who had fallen to his death in the Boiling Gold mine, plunging to the lowest level of the shaft. When the search party finally brought him up, what they found was a replica made of elements.

And now Old Ghost had mentioned that the handler hidden in the central district had heard strange sounds in the pipes of the Second Waterway. It sounded as if something was surging inside them. The Second Waterway in the central district lay very close to one of the levels of the Boiling Gold mine.

Considering that both were “antiques” left over from the Queen’s era fifty years ago, Duncan even suspected that their relationship was more than just “very close”.

Those pipes might even all be connected!

He quickly noted down this clue in his mind, then asked: “From here, is there any way to reach the underground of the central district directly? How do you usually meet with that handler?”

“From here? No, that will not do. There is a passage in between that is pitch black. It was corrupted long ago. The other routes have all collapsed. You

have to go from the surface, but the surface is crawling with the Rebels' lackeys now. You must be very careful…" Old Ghost muttered, then suddenly cried out: "Queen's Guard Corps! The Rebels are here, blow up the shaft, quickly!"

The old man shot up from his bed and stared around in panic, as if the Rebels would storm this place in the very next second. Then he suddenly stopped, and his gaze fell on Alice.

"Oh, I was mistaken. The Queen is safe and sound…"

Alice flailed in a bit of panic and waved her hands: "I… I am not the Queen…"

Duncan looked at the old man by the bed, his gaze deep. But the old man grew dazed again. After a few seconds, he stared blankly at Alice: "Young lady, who are you?"

"Old Ghost, you really are senile now— This is not just the fumes from back then, even your eyes have gone bad!" Nemo's voice suddenly cut through the eerie moment. Nemo nodded to Duncan with an apologetic look. "Sorry. Old Ghost is usually a bit scatterbrained, but he seems worse than usual today. He has not dealt with outsiders for a long time. Seeing you got him excited and he mixed up all those old memories."

"…It is fine," Duncan said calmly, drawing his gaze back from the old man.

He did not care much whether the old man had truly seen a trace of Frostholm's Queen in the disguised Alice. Was it a brief moment of clarity in a muddled mind? Had he seen through the disguise? Or was it just tangled memories? None of that mattered.

If this half-mad old man really saw a faint shadow of Frostholm's Queen in Alice, and felt a moment of peace in his heart because of it, that would be a good thing.

Just then, Nemo seemed to remember something. He frowned: “Strange. Why has Crow still not come back?”

“Crow? He went to check the northern corridor,” Old Ghost waved. “That fellow is a slow one. He always dawdles outside for half the day before he comes back.”

But Nemo’s furrowed brow did not ease at all: “…No. Even if he drags his feet, he should be back by now. The lights over there break down all the time. His consecrated lantern cannot last that long… Old Ghost, when did he leave?”

“Two or three hours?” Old Ghost thought about it and seemed to grow serious as well. “Now that you say it, it really has been quite a while.”

“I have a bad feeling. Crow has been deep in the waterway for too long,” Nemo’s tone finally grew heavy as he raised his head to look at Duncan and the others. “I have to go find him.”

Chapter 356: A Record

The people who should have finished their patrol and returned to the base still had not come back, and it made Nemo feel a bit uneasy.

Duncan spoke up: “Let’s go together.”

He also wanted to walk through this abandoned and mysterious “Second Waterway” and see whether some secret was hidden in this ancient legacy left by the Queen of Frostholm. “With more people, we can look out for each other.”

Nemo glanced, a little surprised, at the burly man in front of him, the “legendary captain” who sometimes made people feel a heavy pressure just by standing there.

To be honest, he still felt as if he were in a fog, as if none of this was real. He had heard the stories that the legendary “Captain Duncan” had returned from Subspace. The Sea Mist had even gone on a special long voyage because of it not long ago. But having Captain Duncan stand right here in front of him was another level of horror altogether. It was the sort of thing where, if he ran to the graveyard and told his dead Grandfather about it, the old man would jump out of the coffin just to tell him to shut up.

Yet it really had happened.

But after this brief contact, Nemo found that this “Captain Duncan” was not as terrifying as the legends said.

He was rational, could talk, and treated people politely. There were several “assistants” following him, and those assistants did not look like puppets controlled by some evil demonic magic.

Now, Duncan had even taken the initiative to offer his help.

This left Nemo a bit at a loss for a moment, but he soon nodded. Compared to figuring out what kind of temper his direct superior, his own old man, might have, the matter of Crow still not coming back was what really could not be delayed.

“I’ll go too,” Old Ghost’s voice came over just then. The old man walked to a nearby storage rack and rummaged through a heap of random “junk.” He found a safety oil lamp he could hang on his chest and a crowbar, then took a coil of rope from another rack and slung it over his body. He stepped toward the door: “No one knows the routes down there better than I do. If that kid really lost his way at some fork, you’ll need the wisdom of an old man.”

Clearly, this old man who drifted between confusion and clarity was in a good state again.

Duncan said nothing. He only signaled for Nemo to lead the way. The group left the Administrator’s little hut, passed back through the wide “junction” from before, and started along a sewer branch heading north to look for Nemo’s subordinate who had still not returned.

Once they passed that junction and went deeper into the “Second Waterway,” Duncan finally realized just how enormous this project really was—and how powerful the city-state under the Queen of Frostholm had been fifty years ago.

Wherever he looked, the walls were solid and the corridors lofty. This so-called “sewer” was almost like a grand underground palace. The

crisscrossing network of passages was clearly not meant only for drainage. It likely had military uses, served as shelter, or even left room for underground factories. Above the wide corridors, pipes spread in every direction. Many of them had rusted badly or even snapped and fallen after years of abandonment, yet they still hinted at how magnificent this system must have been when it was first built.

On both sides of the corridor they sometimes saw large pipe openings and rusted grates. The drainage channels along the edges of the floor had long since dried up. Because this underground waterway had only been in use for a short time and had then been abandoned for many years, there was nothing here but a stale, moldy smell. There was no stench strong enough to be truly unbearable.

Even someone as well-traveled as Morris could not help clicking his tongue in admiration while walking through such an unbelievable facility. But along with his praise, the old scholar suddenly felt a bit puzzled.

“Even if this was built for the city-state’s development a hundred years into the future… this sort of massive underground system is still a bit exaggerated, isn’t it?” he said. “Pland’s sewer system is already considered advanced, but compared with this place it is still far behind. And this was built fifty years ago. Did Frostholm really need such a huge ‘Second Waterway’ back then?”

“The Queen had her own plans. Her judgment was always right,” Old Ghost, walking in front, spoke up as soon as he heard Morris’s doubt. “Her Majesty was a born Psionic. She could always see things ordinary people could not, and she could even see the future of the city-state. She relied on that judgment to make Frostholm strong, and we believed that everything she planned would be useful one day.”

Duncan suddenly frowned.

“A born Psionic?” He looked at the old man carrying the rope and the crowbar. “You’re saying the Queen of Frostholm could, to some extent, predict the future?”

“She said she couldn’t, but we all believed she could. Otherwise, how do you explain those unbelievable decisions she made?” The old man turned his head, his expression firm. “Anyway, that the Queen had supernatural senses is certain. Everyone from our time knew that.”

Duncan looked at Morris beside him. At this moment, Morris also looked thoughtful. He lowered his voice and said: “There aren’t many historical records about the Queen of Frostholm. Most of the information was lost in the rebellion, or was deliberately hidden or altered. In what little I know, there is no record that ‘the Queen was a born Psionic’ or that ‘the Queen had prophetic powers.’ The documents only say that she was extremely intelligent and had a flexible political touch.”

Duncan listened and silently glanced at Alice, who was walking obediently at his side.

She was not intelligent at all and had no idea what “political touch” even meant. She had not yet learned how to spell the word.

Alice noticed the captain’s gaze. She quickly turned her head away, her eyes curving as she smiled.

“…Records can be incomplete, especially when rebels would certainly hide many things on purpose. I’m quite willing to believe that the Queen of Frostholm did indeed have some special traits,” Duncan said, pulling his gaze away and trying to erase Alice’s silly smile from his mind. “It’s just this enormous ‘Second Waterway’ in front of us… What exactly was she thinking when she decided to build such an unbelievable thing back then…”

No one could answer Duncan’s question. At that moment, Vanna suddenly noticed something strange in the distance.

“There’s someone lying on the ground over there!” she called out, pointing ahead.

Everyone looked in the direction she indicated. Sure enough, they saw a figure in a blue coat lying on the ground.

The group ran over. Nemo reached down and turned the person over. A pale face came into view.

“…It’s Crow,” Nemo said. His expression instantly darkened, then he slammed a fist into the floor beside him. “Damn it!”

Vanna crouched beside the already dead young man. She seemed to notice something off about the body. After a closer check, she suddenly frowned: “He… drowned?”

“…Drowned?” Morris was shocked. Then he noticed the wet coat and the unnaturally swollen, waterlogged skin. But when he looked around, he only saw dry floor everywhere nearby. The only trace of water was the damp patch under Crow’s body.

Vanna leaned in even closer. After examining the body for a while, she raised her head: “The smell of sea water. He drowned in the sea.”

“There’s no sea water here. Even the underground river nearby is fresh water,” Old Ghost said as he came up from behind. When he saw the dead Crow, the wrinkles on his face twisted even tighter. “Poor young man. He must have been caught by the rebels, drowned, and then dumped here…”

“Whether it was rebels or not is uncertain, but the corpse being dumped is very possible,” Morris said gravely. “This is clearly not where he died… Hm?”

He seemed to notice something, so he reached into Crow's coat pocket and felt around. He pulled out a piece of paper that had also been completely soaked. A small corner of it had been peeking out earlier, which had caught his eye.

Everyone's gaze fell on that sheet of paper.

Morris pinched the paper between his fingers. Because it had been soaked, it was very fragile, so he unfolded it with great care.

There was writing on it. The ink had been blurred by water, but the words had not fully dissolved.

With the extra light from Old Ghost's oil lamp, Duncan tried to make out the text. The content, however, was baffling. It was a series of broken, incomplete lines:

"…The council of the lost Elder Kings met again and again. The first plan was set. Most of the people in the ashes received protection. They were to stand up in the light and warmth…

"…But the Elder Kings began to argue again. They saw a clan hiding in the shadows…

"The abandoned ones, their flesh would melt in the light. They could not receive divine blessing from the newborn world. The king of this clan came to the council of the lost Elder Kings and asked for the same protection. But what they wanted would be terribly harmful to the others in the ashes, so the lost Elder Kings could not agree. Thus they were abandoned.

"They went into the shadows, imprisoned themselves in the dark places, yet could not fully die. They cried out and searched bitterly for the protection of their homeland, but could not obtain it. So they fled deeper into the darkness. They did not like the dark at first, but only in darkness could they

escape the poisons of this world. And so they lived in the dark for a very, very long time…”

(Under Doomsday, twin moons hung in the same sky and Anomalies lay everywhere. The main character possessed a Probability-Twisting Gift, the O-03 Probability Dice. After he was framed, he set out on a path of revenge and a search for the truth.)

—

Chapter 357: replica

The content on the paper was fragmented. It seemed to hide some vague metaphors. Reading it carefully only made it feel stranger. Even someone as well-read as Morris, a Grand Scholar, had gone over those lines again and again and still found no clue.

What were the lost Elder Kings? What was the abandoned clan? Who were the people in the ashes, and what was the “protection” that kept appearing in those lines?

Duncan frowned tightly. His gaze swept over the ink that had blurred slightly after being soaked in water. Some of the words recorded there stirred faint associations in his mind, but they refused to form any clear line of thought. He only felt that… this did not seem like meaningless mad rambling. Those almost religious paragraphs seemed to be talking about something connected to this “Deep Sea era.”

Or perhaps, about something from before the Deep Sea era.

“Is this Crow’s handwriting?” Vanna suddenly asked. She looked up at Nemo standing beside her.

“It’s his,” Nemo said. He crouched down, studied it, and nodded with certainty. “He always drags out the last stroke at the end of a sentence. No one else has that habit.”

“What did he believe in?” Vanna asked again. “Aside from the Orthodox faith, did he ever come into contact with any other spiritual guidance? It

doesn’t have to be heretical. Secret societies and academic retreat circles, those gray groups count too.”

“He was a devout believer in the God of Death. He had been since he was a child. Other than the Cathedral of Bartok, I’ve never seen him go to any other gathering,” Nemo said, thinking back as he spoke. “As for societies or academic retreat circles… that’s even more impossible. With his brain? A guy who had to spend three extra years in remedial classes just to graduate from a public high school in the Lower City? Even if he wanted to join those circles, they’d have to want him first!”

“…A devout Orthodox believer who never touched any spiritual guidance outside the faith in the True Gods… that makes this very interesting,” Vanna murmured. She looked at the paper in Morris’s hand and pressed a knuckle to her chin. “The style of these passages clearly carries the traces of the classical Age of City-States, or even the earlier Dark Age. And it’s the typical style of Sacred Script. That isn’t something a person who barely managed to graduate from a public high school could just imagine on his own. And Crow kept this right on him. That means he cared a great deal about what was written on it.”

Duncan did not speak. He had been thinking quietly and now suddenly reacted: “So this might be something he copied from somewhere else.”

“Copied?” Nemo froze, then he also caught on. “You mean Crow might have stumbled into some place, and this text… is ‘clues’ he copied down there?”

“Maybe even he didn’t know what these things meant. But this was the most suspicious and most important information he saw in that place,” Duncan said with a slow nod. “And unfortunately, he may have drawn his death to himself while copying it.”

“He stumbled into some place…” Vanna slowly stood up. She crossed her arms, thinking as she spoke. “Then that place must have been completely unfamiliar to Crow, and the environment might have been very strange. So strange that he couldn’t quickly figure out where he was. He could only hurry to record what he saw as clues. On the other hand, he might have been discovered and killed soon after he finished copying, so he had no time to explore further. Otherwise, he would have had a chance to note more distinctive details to describe the environment he saw.”

As she spoke, she lowered her head again to look at the drowned body, her brows knitting together.

“Where exactly did he go? And how was he sent back? A soaking wet corpse would have left some trace while being moved…”

Nemo lifted his head and looked around.

In the dry sewer corridor, there was no sign at all that a body had been dragged through.

“Maybe we should follow the route Crow usually took on patrol and go deeper. He might have left traces before he wandered into that place,” Morris said. He raised his head and looked into the depths of the corridor. “He usually walked in this direction, right?”

“Yes,” Nemo said with a nod. “This corridor leads toward the Upper City. But there’s a stretch where the lighting is unstable and sometimes gets swallowed by darkness. Short periods of darkness don’t cause much trouble, but some… unpleasant things can appear. So it needs regular patrols to find shadows that have just started to grow.”

“Then let’s go take a look. If we go soon, we might still find clues,” Duncan said with a nod. “And if something really has crawled out over there, we can deal with it at the same time.”

No one objected.

The group said a brief farewell to Crow's body and prepared to move deeper along the sewer corridor. Before they passed the young man's corpse, Nemo and Old Ghost both lowered their heads at the same time.

"Wait here for us. We'll come back to get you," Nemo said.

Old Ghost bent down and, from who-knows-where, fished out a triangular amulet. He tucked it into Crow's chest: "Don't go wandering off, kid."

Duncan watched in silence as they said their goodbyes. Only after Nemo and Old Ghost were done did he turn and lead the group onward.

"When we go back, we'll tell Captain Tyrian what happened here," Vanna said suddenly as they walked. "That young man won't die without anyone knowing why."

"Thank you," Nemo said quietly. His mood was clearly bad. A heavy sadness clung to him. "That kid… he never really did anything great in his life. But this time, Captain Tyrian and Captain Duncan will remember him. I guess that counts as some kind of honor."

"Did he have family?" Morris broke the silence with a soft question.

"Family? He hasn't had any for a long time. He grew up in an orphanage. When he was a teenager he left the orphanage and came to be my apprentice," Nemo said, shaking his head. "The head of the orphanage said they picked him up off the street, in a trash bin at the corner. When they first brought him back, he was really only as long as a crow from head to toe…"

"An abandoned child," Old Ghost muttered. There was something like anger in his voice. "When the Queen was still here, she would never have allowed such a thing. Abandoning a baby would get you thrown in jail! And now people have sunk so low they can throw a child into a trash bin… That

kid was tough, though. When he first came to us from the orphanage he was so scrawny. A teenager, but skinny like a monkey. I worried all the time he'd catch a chill one winter and die of it. But he lived… he lived…"

The old man suddenly stopped, as if he had jammed mid-sentence. Then he shook his head, his mood falling: "In the end, he still didn't live."

The atmosphere in the group grew especially heavy. Even the usually dull Alice could feel the weight pressing down. She looked around in confusion, then hesitated and walked over to Old Ghost, as if she wanted to comfort him: "You… don't be sad."

Old Ghost looked up at Alice in her wig and veil and stared blankly for a moment. Then he gave a hard sniff: "Your Majesty, you have to do something about this…"

Alice stared at the old man, completely at a loss.

But her awkward confusion did not last long, because the team suddenly stopped.

The corridor ahead lay under dim, gloomy light. Two gas lamps that seemed to be malfunctioning were set into the walls. Their weak glow could barely push back the darkness ahead. Vanna raised her head and cast her gaze toward the boundary of light and shadow on the floor. Her expression slowly grew more serious.

"There's someone lying there…"

Her voice was low.

A thin-looking figure lay unmoving by the drainage channel at the edge of the corridor. Because the air here did not circulate well, the gas lamps burned weakly. Their faint glow fell across a thick blue coat that looked very familiar.

The group walked up to the fallen body. When Duncan saw the face, he felt no surprise at all. It was Crow.

Unlike Duncan and the others, who had half expected this, Nemo and Old Ghost were only left stunned when they saw that face. There was even a trace of fear.

“Crow?!” Nemo’s voice trembled. He stared at the person on the ground, instinctively taking half a step back. “How… how can this be…”

“It’s a replica,” Duncan said calmly, cutting off Nemo’s cry. From the first glance, he had been certain that this body was a replica formed from elements. Around the “corpse,” patches of thick black goo had already started to appear. The breakdown had begun.

There seemed to be differences between replicas too. Though all of them were formed from elements, some replicas could move around the city-state for ten days or more, while others started to fall apart before they ever reached the graveyard. And this particular replica… was breaking down even faster.

From Crow’s disappearance until now, only a few hours had passed at most.

Thoughts raced through Duncan’s mind.

If Crow really had stumbled into some dangerous and eerie place—like the lair of the Annihilators—and if he had copied that suspicious Sacred Script there, then the process of copying him must also have begun in that place.

And now his replicant lay here, in this area he patrolled so often.

They were heading in the right direction.

Perhaps the source of the replicant was somewhere nearby!

Chapter 358: The End

replica.

After hearing from Duncan and the others what a replica was, and that no one knew how many replicas had already appeared in the city-state, and that their corruption and cognitive interference might already have spread across large areas, a terror that he could not hide appeared on Nemo Wilkins's face.

Even Old Ghost, whose mind went clear and muddled by turns, felt the horror behind this bizarre phenomenon. He kept muttering about the Queen and the Queen's Guard Corps, his face full of anxiety and restlessness. Only after a long time did he finally quiet down.

After that, what Nemo felt was anger.

He could not accept that "Crow", who had followed him for so many years, had died so inexplicably. Even more than that, he could not accept that someone had made a replica of him, and that this replica was lying right in front of him. This was clearly an insult to the dead.

"There are shadows of Annihilators behind this matter. The Guardians in the city should have already started a large-scale hunt. There should be some progress soon," Duncan noticed Nemo's shifting mood and said, "but even if they find those Annihilators, it probably won't solve the problem at its root. The real source is what hides behind those cultists."

"What hides behind those cultists?" Nemo snapped out of his anger as if suddenly waking up. He seemed to think of something at once. "Behind

them… don’t tell me this involves a God-level being?”

Vanna answered him: “replicas are pouring endlessly out from beneath the Deep Sea, and even the Frostholm Queen fifty years ago could not resolve this crisis. Do you really think something like that is something a bunch of cultists can pull off?”

“There are clues that this already involves the Abyssal Lord,” Morris went on. “His power, and even parts of His body, may have already appeared in the Mortal Realm. But as for the details, you had better not ask.”

For ordinary people, taking in too much information that pointed toward Gods was not a good thing.

Nemo heard the faint warning in the old scholar’s tone. He became clear-headed at once and nodded hard: “I understand… I won’t ask.”

He did not want to get strangled to death in his sleep by one of the Abyssal Lord’s tentacles just because he had heard something he should not have heard.

Vanna bent down and examined the “Crow” lying on the floor.

This replica looked vivid and lifelike. At least on the surface, it still kept almost exactly the same appearance as the real person. Only along its edges did foul black “mud” slowly seep out bit by bit. It looked as if the collapse had only just begun.

This was Duncan’s first time seeing, from an outside angle, the process of a replica going from complete to collapsed. This information was also very valuable to him.

He reached out and turned over the pockets of “Crow’s” coat. Earlier, the sheet of paper with the mysterious Sacred Script text had been in this pocket.

The pocket was empty, and its inside was also slowly disintegrating.

Vanna stretched out her hand. Water vapor in the air quickly condensed into an ice blade, and a dagger appeared in her hand. She used this hastily shaped dagger to lift the clothing near “Crow’s” chest and saw that the inner layer of the clothes had turned into a strange fluffy texture. Fibers and clumps stuck together in a blur, merging with the deeper flesh and skin.

“That sheet wasn’t copied… the inside of the replicant shows a typical chaotic state… there’s no blood…” Duncan muttered to himself. He reached out again, wanting to touch the black sludge slowly wriggling on the floor nearby, but he saw it suddenly shrink back, as if it were alive, retreating to the side. “These things haven’t solidified yet, but their writhing is slowing down.”

He slowly stood up and let out a quiet sigh: “There’s nothing else to check. Purify it and remove any future trouble. Vanna, step back a bit.”

As soon as Vanna heard this, she quickly retreated several steps and dragged the still-confused Alice back with her. Old Mr. Morris also backed away with them.

Seeing this, Nemo and Old Ghost also moved back. They had no idea why Vanna and the others suddenly grew so nervous.

Then they found out.

A tuft of ghost-green flame suddenly appeared at Duncan’s feet. In the next instant, the flame leaped toward the nearby “replica” like a predator that had smelled its prey. The blaze surged up, and the sharp crackle of supernatural firewood burning sounded again and again. The corpse formed from that strange black sludge was burned to ash almost instantly. As the flames burned, the gas lamps on the walls, along with the consecrated

lanterns that Old Ghost and Nemo carried, all seemed to take on a ghostly green hue!

The entire process actually lasted less than a few seconds, yet Nemo was already soaked in cold sweat. When the flames had surged up, overwhelming terror flooded his body and mind. He even felt as if his soul was about to resonate with that fire and burn on its own. By the time the flame vanished, he honestly felt as if he had just escaped death.

Duncan turned his head and looked at the people who had almost hidden all the way to the far corner on the other side of the corridor: “It’s burned… why are you hiding so far away? Taking just a couple of steps back would have been fine.”

“I have psychological shadows from that thing,” Vanna said very directly.

Duncan: “…”

He stood there awkwardly for a moment, then touched the bandage near the bridge of his nose and turned to walk deeper down the corridor: “Ahem. Let’s go. Let’s see what’s ahead.”

The others followed after Duncan. Nemo walked a few steps, still shaken, watching the broad back of the man leading the way. Only after a moment did he glance at Old Ghost walking beside him and ask: “Do you think… Captain Tyrian might also be very afraid of his Father?”

Old Ghost seemed not to hear him. He just walked on, a rope hanging from him and a crowbar in his hand, his steps slow, his gaze a little dazed as he looked ahead. Nemo had to call him twice before he suddenly muttered out of nowhere: “That fire… I’ve seen it before…”

Nemo froze: “You’ve seen it? You mean you’ve seen flames like that? Where did you see it?”

But Old Ghost did not answer again. Rope still on his shoulders and crowbar still in hand, he shuffled forward like he was sleepwalking. Then he seemed to suddenly remember something. He hurried to catch up to Duncan and Alice at the front and mumbled as he went: “The Queen is up ahead. Move, move…”

Nemo watched Old Ghost’s back, scratched his hair, and could not help muttering: “Alright, another episode…”

No one knew how much time passed before the group stopped again.

There was no road ahead.

A mass of collapsed boulders and half-melted steel wreckage was piled together, completely blocking the way forward. It looked as if it had been there for half a century.

“This is the end of the corridor,” Nemo said, pointing at the collapsed area. “This was blown up when the Queen’s Guard Corps retreated back then. The whole collapse probably stretches for several hundred meters. There’s no way anyone could pass through.”

“So this is the end… but we didn’t find anything at all along the way…” Vanna frowned and looked back in the direction they had come. “We didn’t even see any marks left by that replica when it moved.”

Duncan said nothing. He walked up to the collapsed ruins and carefully examined the piled stone, concrete, and steel, his brow tightly furrowed and his face silent.

Seeing this, Alice came closer: “What are you looking for?”

“Possible gaps or tunnels,” Duncan said casually. “People can’t get through, but a fluid like mud can seep through very small holes.”

“You suspect… that replica seeped through this collapsed zone first as fluid elements, then condensed into human shape and fell over on the corridor side?” Morris quickly understood what Duncan meant, but the image he formed in his head gave him goosebumps. “That sounds… truly chilling.”

Duncan did not reply. He took two steps back and tilted his head to look up at the completely sealed-off end of the corridor.

There were indeed no signs here.

All along the way, they had seen no trace of any Anomaly.

So how had that replica appeared in the corridor? Where had “Crow” gone before that, and how had he gotten through?

…

On the vast, endless surface of the Boundless Sea, a thin fog had risen.

A steamship with a handsome white hull sailed through the mist. Its bow cut through the fog drifting over the sea, and its stern left layer upon layer of fine ripples behind it.

Captain Lawrence, wrapped in a thick coat, came up onto the deck. He stared into the distance in a daze at the fog-covered sea, the faint line of the horizon, and the silhouettes of icebergs rising and falling in the mist.

It was daytime, and the Sun hung high in the sky. Yet the sunlight neither dispersed the fog over the sea nor drove away the chill in the sea wind. He only felt that cold slowly seeping through his coat, like it was drilling into his bones and soaking into him bit by bit—like his whole body was gradually sinking into icy seawater.

“The northern temperature… really isn’t friendly to an old man like me who was born and raised in the Central Seas.”

Lawrence could not help muttering this to himself.

His First Mate, Gus, walked over from the side. He was a tall, thin middle-aged man with slightly curly brown short hair. Hearing the captain mutter, Gus laughed and said: “Frost Sea is always like this. There’s more fog here than anywhere else, and sometimes it fogs up even in the daytime. The air is full of chill, and there’s sudden snowfall in the city-states… outsiders have a hard time getting used to it.”

“I originally planned to stay in Frostholm for a while longer. But now, once we finish the necessary work, we had better head back quickly. Staying here too long will make a man sick.” Captain Lawrence shook his head. “The fog’s having more and more impact. In an hour, we’ll have to check the heading again.”

The First Mate nodded at once: “Yes, Captain. I’ll make arrangements in a bit.”

Lawrence grunted in agreement, then asked: “Has there been any reply to the signals we sent to Frostholm?”

“Not yet,” the First Mate answered. “But that’s normal enough. The Harbor work efficiency in northern city-states is always like that. Once we get closer, they’ll have to answer our docking request.”

Chapter 359: Stargazing

The White Oak still moved forward through the thin mist. The surging output of its steam core drove its huge, efficient propulsion system and pushed it quickly across this fog-covered stretch of sea.

At some point the sky grew darker. The cold wind over the water felt even more unpleasant. Lawrence pulled his coat tighter, decided that he had been standing in the wind on deck long enough for one day, and turned back into the bridge.

A young priest in a black robe trimmed with silver and blue stood by the machines, giving a benediction. He lightly swung the censer in his hand, letting smoke coil around several control consoles. When he saw the captain enter, he stopped and gave Lawrence a polite nod.

He was the ship’s priest for this voyage, Jensen. Lawrence was not familiar with this young priest. In fact, most captains who transported Anomaly items often had to deal with unfamiliar clergy. The priests on their ships were sent directly by the city-state Cathedral and replaced often. Usually, a ship’s priest would only complete two or three voyages with the same vessel. This constant changing, of course, was for safety.

After all, ships carrying dangerous goods could not avoid exposure to supernatural forces. As the ship’s “supernatural shield”, the priest would bear almost all the pressure from supernatural interference. That pressure came from the items on board, and also from the mental strain that built up among the crew during the voyage—even the Mortal Realm influence from

every crew member’s dreams each night would be fed back into the priest’s daily benedictions and rituals.

But shipboard priests were still mortals. If they stayed under a specific kind of supernatural influence for too long, they would inevitably be affected and changed by it. After several long voyages, they would begin to lose their sharp sense for supernatural corruption, and might even become a crack through which Subspace could invade. So, after some time, priests who served at sea had to return to land and stay for a while in certain Cathedrals, undergoing purification and a reshaping of their Spiritual Insight. Most of them could recover afterward and would then be assigned to other ships as voyage priests again. Those who carried lasting spiritual problems could only stay far from the sea and spend the rest of their lives as priests on land, continuing to serve the Church.

In a sense, these respectable priests were also consumables of seafaring.

Then again… who was not a consumable in seafaring?

“Mr. Jensen, how are the machines?” Lawrence nodded to the young priest and asked with concern.

“Operating well, Captain,” the young priest said in a calm voice. “I just came back from the lower engine room. The whole power system and the steam pipes are all in good condition.”

Lawrence nodded with satisfaction. After exchanging a few casual words with the young priest, he walked to the wide windows at the front of the bridge and looked out.

It was gray outside on the deck. The sky was dimmer, and thick, blurry clouds covered the heavens. A hazy light wandered between the clouds and fell weakly on the sea. The weather was not very good, but they were

already not far from Frostholm, so they probably would not be trapped by a storm or anything else too nasty before reaching the city-state.

Lawrence suddenly frowned and looked at a crew member seated at a console not far away: “Is Frostholm still not responding to our signals?”

“No,” the crew member in charge of monitoring the telegraph system said with a shake of his head. He wore headphones and held a pencil in one hand. A small machine in front of him glowed with an orange-yellow light. “We also haven’t received any reply to our signals. But judging by our position, we’re already close enough to contact Frostholm’s Harbor directly.”

“…That’s not quite right.” The old captain finally felt a trace of unease. He raised his head again and looked into the distance, his expression growing steadily more serious. “At this time, at this position, we should already be able to see Frostholm’s coastline…”

He suddenly turned his head and looked at his First Mate: “Has the route been checked?”

“Just checked it. Our position is correct.”

Lawrence frowned. After a moment, he drew in a quiet breath: “I’ll go confirm it myself. Get the stargazing room ready.”

The First Mate clearly hesitated when he heard this. Before he could speak, the young priest Jensen stepped over and said to Lawrence: “Captain, at your age it’s not really suitable for you to enter the stargazing room…”

Lawrence glanced at the priest but did not speak.

He understood what the man meant. Entering the stargazing room meant taking on a certain amount of corruption. The light and shadow from the layers between the Abyssal Deep and the Spirit Realm put pressure on a person’s mind. As an old captain who had spent most of his life wandering

the Boundless Sea, his mind was no longer as normal and whole as it had been when he was young. While observing the stars, he might very well lose himself.

But in many cases, only older captains had enough experience to see tiny hints of drift in a ship's course from subtle changes in the starlight. Young navigators with healthy minds could not do that.

"I'll finish as fast as I can," Lawrence said at last after they stared at each other for a few seconds. His expression was very serious. "I suspect the ship has gone off course, but there's also drift in the stargazing room. I have experience with recalibration."

Faced with Lawrence's firm attitude, the ship's priest could only sigh and step aside: "…You are the captain. The captain is the law on a ship. I'll prepare the protection."

Lawrence nodded, then looked once more toward the bow.

In the direction where he should have been able to see Frostholm's coastline, there was still only the vast, endless sea and a boundless veil of mist.

He pulled back his gaze and walked toward the passage leading to the stargazing room.

He left the bridge, went down a corridor, and stepped onto a stairway that led to the lower decks of the White Oak. After passing through several connecting compartments and doors, he reached the place where the stargazing room was located.

It was in the lowest level of the ship.

Lawrence stood before the door while the ship's priest, Jensen, began to work. The young clergyman added special incense and holy oil to the censer as he chanted obscure scripture. He swung the chain in his hand so

that the scented smoke slowly spread around Lawrence. Then he took out a small ritual knife marked with many storm runes and used it to cut a line through the air in front of Lawrence, symbolizing the arrival of the protection of Goddess Gamona of Storms.

The White Oak's navigator had already hurried over after hearing the news. He was a young man with a slightly pale face who looked a bit uneasy. When he found out that the captain was going to enter the stargazing room in person to confirm the route, he grew so tense he almost tore the buttons from his clothes.

"Relax a little," Lawrence noticed the navigator's reaction and smiled, comforting the young man instead. "It's not necessarily your fault. The Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep are full of unpredictable changes, and the Spirit Realm lens isn't always reliable. Star charts shifting is normal. You just lack experience. That's normal too."

"I… I checked it over and over. Our route is fine," the young navigator blurted. "But…"

Lawrence waved his hand: "I'll figure out what's going on."

"Captain, the blessing is complete," the ship's priest said from the side at that moment. "You can enter the stargazing room now. But remember, don't stay too long. Don't use the gaze for too long. If you haven't come out in fifteen minutes, I'll go in to fetch you."

"Ten minutes will be enough." Lawrence straightened his clothes and spoke calmly.

Then he let out a soft breath, stepped up to the metal door inlaid with holy silver filaments and carved with storm runes, and pushed it open.

A dimly lit cabin came into view.

Lawrence closed the metal door behind him and quickly took stock of the stargazing room.

The room had no windows. That metal door was the only way in or out. There were no extra furnishings inside, and the only piece of equipment was a cylindrical device about a meter in diameter set in the center of the room.

It looked like an altar, but around its cylindrical base were many cranks, linkages, and mirrored parts. By its side stood a small platform where a person could stand. That was the navigator’s place. At the top of the cylindrical device was a transparent, inward-curving component.

It was a crystal lens held up by a very complex set of struts and rods. The crystal lens was bowl-shaped. Its inside looked empty at first glance, but when his vision focused on it, it seemed as if he could see ripples shining in the lens.

Those ripples were like a basin filled with seawater.

Lawrence stepped up onto the small platform beside the cylinder and looked at the lens in front of him.

A ship sailed across the vast Boundless Sea, and there were almost no landmarks on the water to use as reference. The city-states were islands scattered here and there. Once a ship missed its destination, the sailors would lose themselves on the endless sea. In such a world, navigation became a very important art.

Vision 001, the Sun, was a very useful marker in the sky. Using the Sun to confirm a ship’s direction was one of the basic skills of navigation. But the sky did not always show the Sun, and sometimes the Sun alone could not provide precise enough positioning. When that happened, how could sailors be sure they were still sailing along the right route?

The answer, of course, was to look at the stars.

Stargazing was an essential skill in modern ocean voyages.

Lawrence lowered his head and slowly bent down until his entire face sank into the hollow of the large crystal lens.

The stars were in a place very, very deep down. To see them, a sailor needed not only clever instruments, but also a sound mind.

Chapter 360: Docking

Captains who sailed on the Boundless Sea, especially those who used modern technology for navigation, were of course no strangers to the “stars”. The vast Starry Sky that hung between the Abyssal Deep Sea, and the Spirit Realm could give ships extremely precise guidance. Even when a ship entered waters twisted by an Anomaly, the stars could still point out the correct course. They could even lead those who lost their way inside certain “Visions” out of danger and back to the Mortal Realm.

Of course, other professions also dealt with the Starry Sky. Scholars studied it, hoping to break the mysteries of the world’s deep layers. Diviners watched it to guess at the paths of fate for all things in the mortal world. Some secret societies even treated the Starry Sky as a source of knowledge and revelation. They used dangerous methods that walked on the edge of sanity to pry into it, hoping to grasp secrets about Demons without falling into the Abyssal Deep.

Those dangerous societies often ended as food for Abyssal demons, or became potential “allies” of cultists of annihilation. Because of this, such secret cabals were always key targets for the Churches of the city-states and for the authority.

But no matter what, the profession that had the closest tie to the Starry Sky, and used all kinds of Spirit Realm lenses most often, was still the captains who sailed on the Boundless Sea.

Lawrence had drifted on this vast and hostile sea for half his life. He knew many things about the Starry Sky, including both the methods of observing

it and the dangers that came with it.

He lowered his head and pressed his face deep into the hollow of the Spirit Realm lens – everyone knew you had to bow your head to look at the stars, that was common sense. Then he began to softly recite the name of the God he believed in, letting that name resonate with the blessing the priest had just placed upon him.

As the mysterious power slowly spread, his Spiritual Insight and faith both rose. First he heard a faint sound, as if water was gathering in a basin and drawing near him. He smelled the salty, fishy scent of sea water, and in the next second, he felt that his whole face was already submerged.

New Navigators who observed the Starry Sky for the first time often panicked at this point. The illusion of “drowning in water” could shake their minds, and that would let unnecessary Shadows slip into their heads. That was why a new recruit’s first round of Stargazing always needed someone by their side to help. The main task of this helper was to drag the new Navigator away from the Spirit Realm lens before they mutated into a pile of writhing meat. This “adaptation” process often took several weeks.

But for Lawrence, this was no problem at all.

He knew the “sea water” that flooded over him was the power of the storm Goddess Gamona. A god would not harm a Believer. Now, he could open his eyes.

Lawrence slowly opened his eyes.

The sky full of stars and the endless darkness filled his vision at the same time.

He looked down. Below him the darkness was boundless. The deep gloom of the Abyssal Deep stretched out without end. At the edge of that space,

chaotic ripples of light moved and rolled. That was the faint projection of the Spirit Realm in the deep layers of the world.

Between that darkness, countless fixed and dense points of light floated. They gathered into clumps or wisps of light of all sizes. Some looked like clouds, some like whirlpools, some like rivers. These endless points of light covered the old captain's sight in a spectacular way, outlining some mysterious pattern that Mortals had not yet understood.

And in the depths of that grand, veil-like Starry Sky, in the gaps between some of the "clusters" of light, he could faintly see some chaotic Shadows that were different from the darkness around them. They looked like shattered islands, spread in a radial pattern and floating deep inside the starlight. Dim, pale "rivers" stretched between them. Just one glance could make a person dizzy and trembling with fear.

That was a "depth" even deeper than the Spirit Realm, the terrifying homeland of Abyssal demons – the Abyssal Deep Sea.

The Starry Sky was a layer of Veil that floated between the Abyssal Deep Sea, and the Spirit Realm.

Lawrence kept strict control over his gaze. He did not let himself gaze too far down toward the Abyssal Deep, so he would not attract the attention of those chaotic, dull-minded Demons. At the same time he focused his mind and began to search for his own position within the Starry Sky.

He found it – a dim projection, like a lost and wandering soul, floating somewhere among the stars.

Lawrence fixed his gaze on that projection and studied it for a long time, then could not help but frown.

His own position… was already in the coastal waters near Frostholm?

The old captain’s heart tightened. He started to move his hands by feel and found the control lever on the side of the lens array device. He carefully adjusted the machine. At once the many small lenses set into the side of the cylinder began to work, changing the angle at which Lawrence observed the Starry Sky.

After checking again and again, he confirmed that he really was in the waters near Frostholm – close enough that he should already be able to see Frostholm’s main island with the naked eye.

At that moment, Lawrence felt a sudden blur before his eyes.

The Starry Sky image full of countless points of light flickered once and suddenly turned pitch black, then returned to normal in the next instant.

Lawrence was startled. His first instinct was to adjust the control lever again to reset his view, but long years of experience stopped that instinct. He jerked his head up instead.

A flicker in the Starry Sky image might be a fault in the Spirit Realm lens. No matter what the reason was, once any Anomaly happened in the middle of Stargazing, you had to leave the gaze at once.

This was a safety rule countless predecessors had paid for with their lives.

Lawrence rubbed his brow and raised his wrist to look at his watch. Only a few minutes had passed.

He began to check the whole lens array device. He planned to do another round of observation only after he ruled out any fault and confirmed it was safe.

But just as he was about to open the outer shell of the machine, a knock on the door suddenly cut him off.

“Captain!” The voice of the First Mate came from outside the door. “Captain, have you finished your observation? We received a signal!”

Lawrence frowned a little. After a short pause, he put down what he was doing, walked quickly to the door, and opened it. The First Mate was standing there.

“We received Frostholm’s reply,” the First Mate said. He first glanced into the Stargazing room, roughly made sure there was no sign of an Anomaly, then looked back at Lawrence. “The clearance for near-coast passage and permission to enter the harbor have both been granted.”

Lawrence still frowned slightly. For some reason a faint sense of strangeness rose in his heart. Thinking of the discordant feeling in the Stargazing room just now, he asked in a serious tone: “Can you see Frostholm’s main island?”

“We can already confirm it by sight,” the First Mate nodded. “The fog on the sea has cleared. Our course drifted a little, but it was a very small deviation – and we already corrected it.”

Lawrence glanced back into the Stargazing room, his expression heavy.

“Captain?” The First Mate finally noticed the odd look on the old captain’s face and grew nervous. “Did you find something?”

“There was something wrong with the Stargazing room just now. And according to my observation, we should have been in the waters near Frostholm quite a while ago. There should be no situation where fog or route drift stops us from seeing Frostholm,” Lawrence said in a low voice. “Have an artificer check the Spirit Realm lens array. See if the equipment has a problem. I will go up and take a look.”

“Yes, Captain.”

Lawrence quickly left the bottom deck, went up the stairs and along the corridors, and passed through layer after layer of compartments on the White Oak. Soon he reached the upper deck.

He did not return to the bridge. Instead, he stood directly on the forecastle deck and looked into the distance.

A large city-state lay straight ahead of the White Oak. The coastal buildings and harbor facilities of the city were clearly visible. The fog had scattered. Gentle waves rose and fell over the sea. Thick and thin clouds mixed in the sky. Light spilled down through them, brightening the distant water and the city.

It really did look like Frostholm. There was no sign of any Anomaly.

Lawrence frowned and looked up at the sky.

Aside from somewhat heavy clouds, there was no Anomaly there either.

After a moment, he left the deck and returned to the bridge. At the same time, the sailor at the telegraph machine happened to receive another welcome message from Frostholm’s harbor.

Lawrence looked at the note the sailor wrote down.

“The harbor is open. Welcome to Frostholm.”

Lawrence blinked and suddenly felt he might be a bit too tense. A minor fault in the Spirit Realm lenses plus the fog that had lingered over the sea earlier had probably just magnified his anxiety. In truth, everything here clearly looked normal.

“We dock.”

“Yes, Captain.”

…

Duncan and his group left the “Second Waterway” and said farewell to Nemo in the secret passage that connected to it.

Before that, they had searched for a long time in that collapsed and blocked corridor. In the end they still found no clues. They did not find more of the “mud”, nor did they find any cracks or marks where the “mud” might have seeped into the hallway.

Of course, they did not find the mysterious place where Crow had once lost his way.

It seemed the trail had broken off.

“Old Ghost and I will give Crow a proper burial. Please tell Captain Tyrian that Crow died like a true warrior – he was a member of the Sea Mist Fleet we can be proud of.”

In the secret passage, Nemo took off his hat and bowed slightly to Duncan.

“I will tell him,” Duncan said. He looked at the “informant” before him with special solemnity. “And this investigation is not over.”

Nemo raised his head and met Duncan’s eyes.

“Crow left very important information. He definitely went to some place, and that replica could not have just appeared in the Second Waterway out of thin air,” Duncan said slowly. “I will keep digging. If I have to, I will search this whole city-state, brick by brick, grass by grass, clod by clod.”

Chapter 361: No Trace

Nemo suddenly felt a shudder in his heart.

In that moment, he felt that what this fearsome “ghost captain” had given him was not just a simple promise, but a statement of something that had already become a fixed fact in some day yet to come.

He did not know where this feeling came from. He only knew that he lowered his head without meaning to and spoke with a kind of awe he could not even describe: “As you say.”

Duncan nodded, then moved his gaze as if by chance and looked at Old Ghost, who stood not far away, leaning against the wall and staring blankly.

The old man was no longer muttering about the Frostholm Queen, nor mumbling about the Second Waterway and Rebels. He only stared into space, as if his mind was drifting in some time and place that the world had almost forgotten.

In the old man’s muddled memories… did the Queen of Frostholm still rule this place?

Duncan drew back his gaze, called to Alice, who was also spacing out beside him, and left toward the exit of the secret passage with Vanna and Morris.

Soon they returned to the surface. After leaving the Golden Whistle tavern, they stepped back onto the busy streets of Frostholm.

The setting sun was slowly dropping toward the distant rooftops. The brilliant and mysterious twin rune rings in the sky had just touched the tips of a few spires in the Upper City. Visually, it looked as if the towers built by Mortals were holding up the chains that bound the Sun, making the Sun Wheel hang above the city.

dusk was near, and curfew time was coming. Because of the stricter new curfew order, everyone hurried home or toward the nearest nightfall Sanctuary World. In the middle of this rushing crowd, Duncan's group, walking at an easy pace, looked quite out of place.

But not many eyes landed on them. Everyone was busy.

"What do you think about this?" Vanna moved up beside Duncan and spoke in a low voice. Because they were about the same height, she could lean in close.

Duncan's face did not change: "You mean the origin of that replica?"

"It seemed to appear out of nowhere. The ways Morris and I used to investigate could not find any trace of how it moved. Even you did not find a clue," Vanna said, nodding lightly. "And we always believed that even these strange replicas had to move in some 'normal' way. They should have a source and a process of moving from place to place…"

Duncan slowed a bit and tilted his head: "You mean those replicas might have some kind of spatial power that lets them ignore the dimensions of the Mortal Realm and appear directly at a chosen place?"

"That is my suspicion."

Duncan gave no clear answer. A few seconds later, he suddenly said: "Have I ever told you what happened the first time Alice came aboard the ship?"

"No," Vanna blinked. "Did something happen when she first came aboard?"

“The doll’s spirit coffin kept returning to the Vanished. I threw her into the sea three times, and she and her wooden box came back to the ship three times,” Duncan said slowly. “Guess how she came back.”

Vanna thought for a moment and said, not very sure: “By relying on… the power of the curse? Some kind of ‘recurrent gift’ of Anomaly 099? Also a spatial kind of power?”

“No. She rowed back on the coffin lid, very fast,” Duncan said in a calm tone. “Then she climbed straight up along the hull of the ship with a lot of strength. Because she rowed too fast, I did not catch her the first two times. I only grabbed her on the third try.”

Vanna: “…”

The young Inquisitor and Morris both turned their heads at the same time. With a strange look in their eyes, they stared at the doll Miss, who was glancing around at the side. Feeling their gaze, Alice turned her head and gave them an innocent smile.

“I am not ruling out the idea that those replicas use some kind of spatial teleportation to appear directly inside the city,” Duncan went on lightly. “But logically, if they could Teleport straight into the city, then why did the Sea Swallow have to sail all the way from the outer sea instead of just appearing in the harbor?”

“I am more inclined to think the replicas still need normal means of movement. That replica in the sewers only looked like it ‘appeared out of thin air’ because we overlooked something. It is like how normal people would never guess that the real reason a cursed doll keeps ‘coming back’ is simply that she swims very fast and is very strong.”

He paused for a moment, then added, deep in thought: “It is more likely that the place Crow ‘strayed into’ also came from the same kind of ‘overlooked’

path.”

Morris, who had been quiet the whole time, suddenly reacted: “Some kind of passage that exists but cannot be observed? Or a rift that opens only at times?”

“Hard to say. But this matter is definitely tied to those cultists,” Duncan said. “What Crow recorded on that sheet of paper caught my attention. It did not all sound like rambling ‘Heretic thoughts’. It sounded more like a description of real events, written in words modern people cannot easily understand. That kind of record has always suited the taste of cultists.

“Maybe we really should bring Dog and Shirley here. The eyes of Abyssal demons might be able to see something in dimensions outside the Mortal Realm.”

…

A gust of gray wind swept into the door of the harbor defense office. From the Ashen Wind, Gatekeeper Agatha stepped through.

Behind the desk, Colonel Lister looked up at the Gatekeeper who had appeared in his office: “This time you even skipped the usual notice.”

“Sorry. It is an urgent moment,” Agatha said. Then she noticed the two heavy dark circles on Lister’s face. “You did not sleep last night?”

“I was not the only one awake,” Lister said with a bitter smile, shaking his head. “We spent the whole night trying to crack the mysterious signals from the Sea Mist Fleet. The cryptographers and mathematicians almost started hitting each other with chairs. It is the first time I learned that refined scholars can also start cursing each other’s relatives when they argue.”

Agatha stayed quiet for a moment, her gaze turning a bit strange. After a while, she said: “Soon the Cathedral may ‘borrow’ a few Scholars from you, especially in cryptography and mathematics.”

Lister froze: “Why?”

Agatha’s expression did not change much – half her face was covered in bandages anyway: “To crack another playful secret left to us by another being with a bad sense of humor.”

“All right, looks like your troubles are no less than mine,” Lister sighed, then pulled himself together. “Let us talk business. Why did you drop by so suddenly? What do you want to know?”

“The state of the lockdown,” Agatha said. “Normally the Cathedral should not interfere with city defenses, but things are special now. I cannot rest easy.”

“I understand,” Lister nodded. “Do not worry. All of Frostholm is now completely sealed. Even if there are places not fully covered, with such a huge Sea Mist Fleet gathered in the nearby waters, no one would dare move in or out casually. We have temporarily frozen all departure permits and informed nearby city-states and ships on the outer sea to stay away from Frostholm. Every docking request we have received so far has been rejected.”

“Good. At least that stops the problem from getting worse,” Agatha said with a light breath. “What about Dagger Island?”

“It is still under lockdown, until the Cathedral gives us further ‘professional advice’,” Lister said, his face growing more serious. “Up to yesterday, the island continued to send back regular reports saying ‘all normal’. Even after the city stopped sending supplies and cut off all communication replies, there was no other reaction from them.”

“Do not relax your guard. The Sea Swallow incident proved that the corruption on that island is actively trying to move into the city,” Agatha said sternly. “That ‘thing’ will not just sit there quietly. The Cathedral is

already preparing a force made up of Deathsworn and penitent Monks, but unsealing the powerful sacred relics will still take some time."

Lister nodded. He seemed about to say more, but before he could speak, hurried footsteps sounded from the corridor outside.

A harbor soldier appeared at the office door.

Lister looked up at him. The soldier's face carried a hint of haste. "What happened?"

The soldier straightened up and reported quickly: "Report, Commander. A ship that was scheduled to dock at Frostholm has not appeared on time."

"Not appeared on time? That is meaningless," Lister frowned. "All routes around the city are sealed right now. Of course no ship will dock."

"Report, Commander, it is not that it failed to dock – it has not appeared at all!" the soldier quickly explained. "That ship was supposed to arrive today. We were already prepared to send it the notice about the city's lockdown, but it never contacted us. We just talked to Cold Harbor again. Cold Harbor confirmed that the ship completed its resupply and inspection there as normal. But after it approached the waters near Frostholm, there has been no more word from it!"

Hearing this, Lister's expression finally turned grave. He drew in a slow breath and rose from behind the desk: "What is the name of that ship?"

"The White Oak!"

Chapter 362: The Sinking Island

Agatha stepped forward and spoke in a serious tone: “Where did that ‘ship that never arrived’ come from?”

“It departed from The Harbor, Pland, took on supplies once at Lunsa, then again at Cold Harbor,” the soldier who had come to report answered at once. “Frostholm was supposed to be its final stop—until the resupply at Cold Harbor, everything about that ship was completely normal.”

“Damn it…” Colonel Lister pressed hard on his forehead, his mood clearly very bad, and said: “We already have more trouble than we can handle… and now another ship vanished just as it was about to reach Frostholm… We barely have the energy to deal with our own city, let alone anything outside its borders…”

Agatha turned her gaze on the Defense Commander and spoke in an especially grave tone: “But as you said, Colonel, it vanished when it was just about to reach Frostholm—so we cannot rule out that it was also affected by some kind of supernatural Vision.”

Lister looked up: “You mean…”

“Frostholm is being tainted by some sort of supernatural power. Anomaly cases keep breaking out in the city. The Sea Swallow incident proved that this ‘strangeness’ is not limited to the main island. Now another ship, the White Oak, has gone missing at the edge of our coastal waters. I have reason to suspect that a ‘Visions’ event on a scale far beyond what we

imagined is covering the entire Frostholm region—not only the land under our feet, but also a large stretch of the surrounding sea."

Lister braced his hands on the table. After a few seconds he suddenly looked up: "We need to widen the blockade and warn every nearby city-state. Frostholm's corruption is spilling outward. A simple physical blockade may not work at all."

As he spoke, he suddenly stopped. He bit his teeth, clearly torn. Agatha of course noticed: "What else is troubling you, Colonel?"

"…I'm afraid we have to talk to that Pirate Lord," Lister said, his face dark. "Though I personally, really, really do not want to do it."

"You mean… Tyrian Abnomar?" Agatha's tone also changed a little. Though she served as the city's Gatekeeper, she was still a native of Frostholm, raised on horror stories about the Sea Mist Fleet. "If you don't go to sleep, Captain Tyrian will come during the thick fog and carry you away" was the deepest childhood memory of every Frostholm native under fifty. Agatha was no exception. "Do you think he will agree to talk with us?"

"Not necessarily a negotiation, but at least a conversation," Lister said, lifting his eyelids and fixing his gaze on the Gatekeeper before him. "He arrived here at the most sensitive possible moment, yet he has not taken any further action. I once suspected he was linked to the 'replicas' appearing inside and outside the city, but now he looks more like he is simply sealing off this region—just as we are. We have to send someone to speak with him, at least to figure out what he intends to do."

"…Legend says he is a cursed man, cold and mad, whose breath is as icy as the winds over the Frost Sea, and whose gaze can freeze the sea itself," Agatha said softly. "Who could serve as this 'Envoy'?"

“Those stories are exaggerated. Anyone with a bit of access can find out that the Sea Mist Fleet has fairly normal channels of contact with many powers on the Frost Sea. That so?called ‘Sea Mist Venture Company’ even has an ‘office’ in Cold Harbor. That Pirate Lord is simply especially cold toward Frostholm,” Lister sighed softly. “The Envoy problem will be solved. Our city has never lacked for brave soldiers, and besides…”

He suddenly stopped, lifted his head in thought, and looked toward a certain direction outside the window.

“Lady Agatha, did you just hear something strange?”

“A strange sound?” Agatha frowned and also raised her head to look outside. Almost at the same time, she too heard some distant, low, odd noise.

It sounded like a continuous humming, yet it was unlike any sound she knew of in the natural world.

It came from the direction of Dagger Island.

On the Frostholm Nearshore Waters, an Ironclad Warship with a white hull and three main guns cruised slowly along, flying the Queen’s flag. A short, stocky captain stood at the bow, watching the distance through a spyglass. He wore a Guard Corps uniform from half a century ago, the kind once issued by the Queen. Yet there was a gaping hole in his abdomen, so wide you could see straight through him. The torn cloth around the wound floated in the air as if soaked in seawater, and now and then a string of bubbles appeared from nowhere.

He was a member of the Sea Mist Fleet, captain of the powerful warship Sea Crow, Nixon.

He gazed toward the small island in the distance, with its winding shoreline.

On the sea in that direction, a few small, dark shapes prowled back and forth.

They were Frostholm's navy ships. They blocked off Dagger Island from the other side, and at the same time watched every move of the Sea Crow and the other nearby Sea Mist vessels with great care.

"Those ships are really annoying," a Sailor strolled up beside the short, stocky Captain Nixon and said: "Can we fire a few shells at them to say hello?"

"No, unless you want General Tyrian to stuff you into the engine room and churn you for twenty?four hours," Nixon said without even turning his head. "We are not here to fight the people of Frostholm. In the General's words, for now we stand on the same side as they do."

"Fine," the Sailor shrugged. "They're blocking the other side of Dagger Island and we're blocking this one. Not bad 'cooperation,' I guess. But if those guys lose their heads and really come too close, they can't blame us if our guns 'misfire,' right?"

"If they misfire, you'll be the first one we launch," Nixon glanced back at his subordinate, then turned his eyes again to the distant island. "Dagger Island… tch. I still remember standing guard on it back in the day."

"Back then it still had Boiling Gold to mine. There was even a town on the island," the Sailor sighed. "Ah, those good days are gone for good."

Nixon frowned, as if he wanted to say something more, but suddenly he seemed to hear a sound. His expression turned serious at once.

A strange buzzing sound… reached his ears.

"What's that noise?" The Sailor beside him reacted at once, his face tense. "Did those Frostholm ships make it?"

“I don’t know, but the Frostholm ships aren’t doing anything suspicious…” Nixon quickly raised his spyglass. “They don’t seem to know either… wait, Dagger Island is shaking!”

He jerked the spyglass down and stared in shock at the distant sea.

A hazy shroud of mist was rising from the direction of Dagger Island. The deep humming came from there, boring into his thoughts and churning his mind. He saw the island come alive. Blurred tendrils spread from its edges, rising and writhing within the mist, stirring the surrounding sea and fog again and again. The island itself slowly sank, while countless huge Shadows rose on its surface, looming in the fog like giants getting to their feet.

Nixon froze for a moment, then hurriedly raised his spyglass again, wanting a closer look at what was happening on the island.

Yet just as he was about to do so, a thunderous boom suddenly rang out from that mist?filled stretch of sea. It was followed at once by countless rapid explosions. Smoke billowed up over the island and blended with the surrounding sea mist. Flashes and pillars of fire shot into the sky, clear to see even without a spyglass.

Dagger Island had been detonated. Every installation on the island was blowing up, and every so?called “ultimate safety measure” pointed to the same answer: Protocol Twenty-Two, Nitroglycerin charges.

Nixon stared, dumbstruck, at the scene. It took him a moment to grasp what had happened, and then what he saw next once again went beyond his imagination.

Dagger Island was sinking, like a warship whose hull had been blown open, dropping fast amid the chain of explosions.

“The island is sinking?” came his subordinate’s shocked cry beside him. This Sailor, who had served on ships for more than half a century, had never seen such a sight. “The people of Frostholm… blew Dagger Island to the bottom? They can sink an entire island?!”

“Nonsense! There’s no such explosive in the world—how could an island be ‘blown’ to the bottom?!” Nixon barked on instinct, but the sight before him swallowed the rest of his words.

Dagger Island really was sinking, and the pace only grew faster. In the end it reached an unbelievable speed. One minute he could still see two?thirds of the island above the water. A minute later only a small hilltop remained. A few seconds after that… the island had vanished from the sea’s surface.

The thin mist faded. On the Frost Sea, there was no sign of Dagger Island anymore.

“Not even a whirlpool…”

Captain Nixon swallowed hard and muttered in disbelief.

The distant sea was still calm. In theory, an island sinking would create a terrifying maelstrom, big enough to swallow the greatest warships in the world. Yet in fact… no whirlpool appeared at all.

It was as if… the island had not sunk, but melted into the sea.

Chapter 363: Martha

“Smack!”

The papers in his hand slammed onto the desk. Lister sprang up from behind it—he almost jumped to his feet. The Harbor District Defense Commander stared wide?eyed at the subordinate in front of him: “Say that again?! What happened to Dagger Island?!”

“Dagger Island… Dagger Island has disappeared!” The soldier who had come to deliver the news stammered. Even as a well?trained Warrior, he could hardly control himself in this situation. “Just now, we saw a series of explosions on Dagger Island, likely the last people on the island blowing up the remaining facilities… After that, the fleet on patrol nearby watched with their own eyes as the island sank quickly and vanished from the sea’s surface…”

“The fleet wasn’t affected?” Lister frowned at once. Something felt wrong.

“No,” the soldier shook his head. “While Dagger Island was sinking, it hardly disturbed the surface of the sea. The report from the front says… it looked as if the island quietly melted into the water.”

Lister’s expression grew especially grim. He stayed silent for a few seconds, then looked up at the Gatekeeper still standing in the office: “Lady Agatha, in your knowledge, is there any known divine magic, sacred miracle, or supernatural item that can cause a phenomenon like this?”

“No,” Agatha shook her head without hesitation. “An Anomaly of this scale is already beyond the category of spells. It should be classed as a divine

miracle—or some sort of Visions event.”

“…Whatever the case, we’re in deep trouble. The investigation hasn’t even begun. We still know nothing about what was really happening on Dagger Island, and now the whole island has vanished from the sea. City Hall will not like this news,” Lister said, brows tightly furrowed as he tapped the tabletop with his fingers. Then he seemed to think of something and snapped his head up to look at the soldier. “Right—how did the Sea Mist Fleet respond?”

“They’re still in their old positions and haven’t crossed the near?sea warning line,” the soldier answered at once. “But after Dagger Island disappeared, two of their fast boats briefly approached that stretch of sea. They stayed there for about ten minutes, then hurried back.”

“Sounds like they were observing the situation… It seems this caught them off guard too,” Lister said slowly. “Damn it. Looks like we really do have to talk to that Pirate Lord.”

“The Cathedral will act as well,” Agatha went on. “At this point, the plan to explore Dagger Island is meaningless. We will shift our strength to a full sweep inside the city. Our Guardians have already found leads on the Annihilators and several possible meeting sites. I will personally lead a team to deal with them.”

“I hope you gain something, Lady Gatekeeper,” Lister said, lifting his head to look at the black?robed priestess of the Goddess before him. “This matter is in a runaway state. We need help from the supernatural field more than ever, and the Cathedral’s investigation has already been moving far too slowly.”

“We will do everything we can.”

Agatha nodded lightly, then lifted the Gatekeeper’s cane and tapped it twice on the floor. With the sound of the cane striking the boards, her figure suddenly turned into a swirl of Ashen Wind, which coiled once and sank into a pale fissure that opened out of thin air on the floor.

Lister watched the place where Agatha had vanished. Only after the fissure closed did he sigh and drop heavily back into his chair. At the same time he told the soldier: “Go out and close the door.”

Next, he had to write an express dispatch to City Hall as quickly as possible, to try his best to explain the strange madness that had taken place right on the city’s doorstep.

…

At the harbor, the city’s staff were using mental guidance to bring ships to the docks. Men and women in black or blue uniforms stood on the concrete piers, each busy with their own tasks in the icy wind. They hardly spoke to one another, silent and absorbed in their work.

A little farther away, several other ships lay moored. They seemed to have been here for some time. Only a few people moved about on their decks. Their loading and resupply work had already finished; they were likely waiting for the next round of departure paperwork.

Farther still, one could see the main road leading into the urban district. The wide street stretched toward the tall buildings in the distance. The gas lamps lining the road had not yet been lit, but because it was nearly evening, there were not many people in sight. Only a few carriages hurried along the darkening street.

Lawrence stood at the edge of the deck, gazing at the city’s buildings in the distance.

This was not his first time in Frostholm, but it had been many years since his last visit. The long gap, and the way memory faded with age, left him unable to recall what the city used to look like. Now, as he stared at the distant spires and towers standing in the dusk, he felt only a deep sense of unfamiliarity.

Still, the White Oak had at last docked safely in this city?state. The weather had been especially bad all along the way, but in the end they had not run into any storm or other disaster.

Footsteps came from behind him. The old captain turned and saw his First Mate.

“The inspection is almost over,” the First Mate said. “Everyone asked me to check if we can go into the city today. After this whole trip, they’re sick of being stuck on the ship.”

Lawrence looked up at the sky. The World’s Wound had not yet appeared, but the last glow of daylight was already fading away. He frowned and shook his head: “It’s too late. After nightfall there’s a curfew in the city. There’s nowhere worth going if you land now. Everyone stay on the ship and behave yourselves. In a while I’ll go to The Harbor’s administration office and handle the remaining paperwork. Tomorrow morning the others can come ashore.”

“All right, I’ll pass that on,” the First Mate said with a smile, then casually asked: “But you’re going alone? Want me to send a couple of people with you?”

“No need. I can already see The Harbor’s office door—it’s right by the pier,” Lawrence waved a hand and pointed toward a light not far on shore. “Once The Harbor inspectors leave, check every hold on the ship again, especially the lower deck that stores the sacred relic and the sealed vaults. Make sure no careless fool has tampered with the safeguards.”

“Yes, Captain.”

The First Mate left. Lawrence drew a shallow breath of the night air. The biting wind from the Northern Seas poured into his lungs and made him shiver awake.

The old captain shook his head, grumbling a little about the awful weather here, then walked toward the nearby stairs.

A figure stood at the top of the stairs, arms folded, watching Lawrence calmly from within the crisscross of dim lights.

Lawrence hesitated and stopped. After studying her for a moment, he spoke, unsure: “…Martha? Why are you here too?”

“If I were you, I wouldn’t be asking questions right now. I’d be leaving at once,” the female mariner said. She folded her arms and turned her gaze on the old captain, her tone tinged with helplessness. “Your guard has slipped, Lawrence.”

“Martha, I…” Lawrence stepped forward half a pace without thinking. He faintly felt something was wrong, but countless words stuck in his throat. He could only reach out to her clumsily. “I’ve missed you a bit… How have you been lately?”

Martha did not answer him. The female mariner only gave him a calm look, her gaze seeming to focus on somewhere far beyond him. In the soft sea wind and the sound of gentle waves, she slowly began to hum:

“Hoist the sails, hoist the sails, the sailor who left home keeps moving on…

“In the wind and waves, in the noise, only a single board stands between us and death.

“Reef the jibs, spread the mainsail, cast off the ropes, hold tight to the rail—we have come to the middle of the sea…”

Martha’s voice grew lower and lower until she finally stopped. Her eyes refocused on Lawrence, and in a voice that sounded almost like she was talking to herself she said softly: “Lawrence, be careful. You have come to the middle of the sea.”

Lawrence drew in a sharp breath. The cold air jolted his mind awake. At once he seemed to remember something. He grabbed at his chest and fumbled in his pocket, fast but clumsy.

Martha took a step and slowly walked toward him.

“Lawrence, how did you get so old?” The female mariner reached out her hand. Her hoarse voice held a trace of gentleness. She still looked young. Though her face carried a few marks left by life at sea, she was just as beautiful as in Lawrence’s memory. “It’s been many years, hasn’t it? You’re not young anymore… and neither am I…”

“Martha…” Lawrence’s throat worked. He felt his fingers were about to touch the little bottle, yet he missed it again and again.

He could almost smell Martha’s scent—the familiar trace of lemon. It had always been her favorite fragrance.

His hand found the little bottle.

“Martha…”

He took it out and held it in his hand, but his feet felt rooted to the deck. He watched the woman from his memories reach out to him, just like in his countless dreams. That hand carried a familiar warmth as it slowly brushed his hair. He saw the woman from his memories smile, as if she meant to tell him about all the longing of their years apart…

“Martha, I’m sorry.”

Lawrence clenched the vial and poured the bitter medicine into his mouth.

Martha vanished.

Chapter 364: Sneaking Away

Martha disappeared, as if she had never existed in the first place.

Yet the warm touch still lingered at his temple, and the faint lemon scent still hung around his nose. It seemed she had never come, yet also had never left.

Lawrence felt his fingers tremble. He lowered his head. It took several tries for him to screw the tiny cap back onto the bottle. Then he spent a long time putting it back into the inner pocket of his coat. His heart pounded wildly. Even when he faced a great storm, his heart had never beaten like this.

Reason came late, like waking from a long dream. He realized that just now he had brushed past madness and had almost sunk into a lasting state of delusion. For a captain who had drifted on the Boundless Sea for most of his life, once he fell into such a state, he would never regain his sanity. Yet at this moment he felt neither relief at having survived nor fear from facing that madness.

He only felt a distant sadness and regret.

And this distant sadness and regret were a warning. They meant that deep in his heart he no longer resisted the “madness” itself.

Lawrence drew in a deep breath and tried to throw all those thoughts that tangled around his mind out of his head. He glanced to the side. The White Oak lay under his feet, and a whole ship of people were waiting for him to take them back to Pland.

This was not the time to fall into madness.

The old captain sighed and said: “I really should retire…” He slowly started toward the stairs in front of him. But after only a few steps, he suddenly stopped, his face turning a bit grim.

He remembered the scene from when “Martha” had appeared just now. He knew such “memories” were dangerous and might make her appear again, yet he could not help thinking about them. He had suddenly realized that some of the things “Martha” had said to him were very hard to ignore:

In his memory, Martha’s voice sounded again: “Lawrence, be careful. You have come to the middle of the sea…”

Her voice went on: “If I were you, I would not have any extra questions now. I would leave here at once… Your guard is down…”

Lawrence repeated these two sentences in his heart without thinking. He knew very well that what had just happened was only a hallucination born from broken memories and shaken perception. Even so, he could not help taking those two sentences as some kind of warning. Martha might not exist, but had he sensed some danger deep in his intuition? Were these two sentences his own subconscious trying to warn him?

The old captain looked around and carefully checked the White Oak again. Everything he saw looked normal. Then he lifted his head and looked at the nearby city-state of Frostholm.

Frostholm also looked normal. The nearby Harbor district seemed quiet and peaceful. Lights had already begun to shine in the city blocks not far away. Farther out, a high sea cliff looked down over the ocean, its outline hard and strong under the dim sky.

But a faint sense of wrongness rose in him, unstoppable like a tide climbing in his heart. With that feeling came a soft sound of waves by his ear. It

overlapped with the real waves around the White Oak. At first he did not tell them apart, but soon he realized that this sound rang directly inside his mind.

The sound of waves… was it a warning? Was the blessing of the storm Goddess Gamona taking effect?!

Lawrence's eyes hardened. He at once gave up the idea of going ashore and spun around, rushing toward the bridge. The cold night wind howled past his ears, cutting at his nerves like a blade.

The First Mate on duty at the bridge saw Lawrence appear so suddenly and looked shocked. He rose from his chair, hurried over, and said: "Captain? Weren't you going ashore…"

Lawrence spoke quickly: "The situation has changed. I feel something is very wrong… How long have we been docked here? Has anyone slipped ashore?"

The First Mate answered at once: "No. You already ordered everyone to stay on the ship. They have all been behaving. Also, we have been docked here for several hours."

Lawrence nodded quickly: "Good, no one went ashore. Fire up the steam core. We are leaving this Harbor."

The First Mate froze for a moment and said: "Huh… what? Leave this Harbor? We just…"

Lawrence cut him off: "Something is wrong with this place. I can't explain it, but I have a very bad feeling. Remember when the Stargazing Room had a problem earlier? And before that, when we could not contact Frostholm? From that time on, everyone's guard has been dropping. Something… is affecting all of us."

He spoke fast, and at the same time he knew how abnormal his order was. Aside from the faint wrong feeling in his gut, he had no proof that his command was right. The White Oak had just finished a long voyage. Both the crew and the machinery needed repairs and rest. In such a situation, his order to leave port was almost nonsense.

Besides, leaving port had to be coordinated with the Harbor authorities. Reigniting the steam core without reporting it was a serious violation. He would have to bear the consequences of his decision.

But the fierce sense of alarm thumped in his heart, and the sound of waves in his mind grew louder and louder. The blessing of Gamona warned him not to keep in contact with the Harbor, not even to say a single extra word.

The First Mate fixed his gaze on the captain in front of him. After nearly half a minute, he suddenly stood straight and said loudly: “Yes, Captain!”

On a ship, the captain’s word was law.

A captain who lost his mind could take the whole crew to their grave. But with much higher odds, an experienced captain could save everyone on board from danger.

The order quickly spread through the ship. The confused sailors were pushed to move, and soon their trained reflexes had them ready to set sail again.

Fresh Boiling Gold catalyst was inserted into the steam core. A deep mechanical vibration woke in the depths of the White Oak. The sailors quietly loosened the mooring lines along the rail and pulled the gangplank back onto the deck. Lawrence stood on the bridge, watching the movements on the pier through the wide glass windows.

Some figures moved about on the pier. Under the dim light of the gas lamps, their shapes looked vague and unreal. A few loading vehicles drove

past a little farther away, leaving long, heavy shadows on the road.

They seemed not to notice at all that a ship had reignited its steam core in the darkness, and nothing suddenly appeared to block the White Oak as it quietly prepared to leave.

Things were already better than he had imagined. In Lawrence's worst fears, he had even worried that at the very moment the steam core flared back to life, hundreds or thousands of sea monster tentacles would suddenly rise from the waters around them and drag the White Oak straight under.

Lawrence quickly spoke to the First Mate beside him: "Keep the lights under control. Do not sound the steam whistle." He stepped up to the helm and took the wheel with his own hands. "I will steer myself. Keep the boiler at high pressure and be ready to overload at any time."

The First Mate answered: "Yes, Captain."

Though doubts still lay in their hearts, everyone on the ship carried out the old captain's orders without hesitation. Lawrence could feel the steel giant under his feet slowly starting to move.

The whole ship kept its lights under strict control. The propellers below the water began to turn. The White Oak slowly pulled away from the Harbor, and the churning of the water grew louder. Everyone grew tense, and every gaze turned toward the city-state beside them, now wrapped in night.

Lawrence felt sweat in his palms.

But the city showed no sign of any Anomaly. Even though the White Oak's movements could no longer be hidden, no one came to check on them.

He glanced at the radio console beside him. The telegraph machine was as silent as death.

In theory, the Harbor authority should have sent an urgent message by now. The Harbor official on duty would be demanding to know why the White Oak was leaving port so suddenly. But nothing happened.

This instead strengthened Lawrence's resolve and made him believe his judgment was right.

There really was something wrong with this place!

The power of the steam core rose a level. The propellers spun faster and faster. The White Oak left the dock area at growing speed. Open sea appeared in front of the bridge, the surface glittering with faint waves of light.

Lawrence took a deep breath and gripped the wheel hard: "Bring her to full speed!"

…

A gust of Ashen Wind swept across the courtyard and took shape in the front hall of the great Cathedral. Agatha stepped out of the Ashen Wind. She hurried through the porch and the main hall and came to the "Meditation Hall" where the city-state's Bishop Ivan stayed.

The statue of the God of Death Bartok stood quietly at the far end of the hall. A dark coffin lay on the platform at the statue's feet, its lid standing open. Bishop Ivan, who usually rested in that coffin, stood beside it now and looked up toward Agatha.

This Bishop looked like a mummy, his whole body wrapped in bandages with only one eye showing. Today he wore a black robe edged with gold and held a tin staff in his hand. As Agatha came closer, he spoke first: "I have already heard about what happened on Dagger Island."

Agatha nodded and said: "I can see you plan to chair the meeting yourself. Can your body handle it?"

Bishop Ivan raised his hand. Pale gray mist seemed to drift slowly from the gaps in his bandages.

He said: “As long as either the body or the will can hold on, that is enough.”

Chapter 365: The Child Sharing a Secret

Agatha knew that Bishop Ivan's life had been near its end many years ago. Under those tight bandages, almost no flesh-and-blood body remained. What kept him standing here, aside from the sacred miracles bestowed by Bartok, was only a stubborn soul.

Few people knew what had really happened to this Bishop's body. Even Agatha, as a Gatekeeper, only knew that it came from an "accident" many, many years ago. Bishop Ivan never spoke about the truth of that "accident", not even in front of her.

Naturally, Agatha did not take the initiative to touch this secret.

Bishop Ivan's mood was clearly heavy. He stayed silent for a long time before suddenly saying: "We are facing a crisis."

Agatha nodded: "Yes, Bishop Ivan. I will do my best to find the truth and break the plots of those Annihilators."

But Bishop Ivan shook his head: "No, you do not understand. The 'truth' of this crisis may already lie beyond our understanding and imagination, Agatha. The activities of those cultists may be one part of this crisis, but they are not all of it. I have a feeling…"

Agatha frowned slightly: "A feeling?"

"It is a similar air. It is like fifty years ago… Before that chaos broke out, the whole city was filled with a mood very close to today," Bishop Ivan said

slowly. “The city-state looked normal on the surface, yet strange details showed everywhere. It was as if we were suddenly living inside a dream where truth and lies were hard to tell apart. From time to time we would glimpse horrible scenes at the edge of that dream, yet the sad minds of Mortals refused to understand any of it. That kept us from seeing the reality right in front of us… Do you feel that? As if… distortion is right before our eyes, and we keep them shut.”

“I do not understand…” Agatha said, a bit unsure. “Do you mean cognitive interference? That this interference has already affected our judgment?”

Bishop Ivan did not answer her. After several seconds of silence, he suddenly brought up a topic that seemed unrelated: “Agatha, have I ever told you about the ‘last Queen’s Guard Corps’ from fifty years ago? Have I ever told you about the ‘Second Waterway’ deep under the city-state?”

“Second Waterway?” Agatha paused, and some information rose in her mind. “I know a bit about it. It was part of a huge underground system the Frostholm Queen built for the city-state. But when the Queen’s era ended, that unfinished project was abandoned. Now, because of heavy cave-ins and a lack of funds, it still lies abandoned down there. Most people do not even know it exists.”

“Yes, abandoned,” Bishop Ivan said with a shake of his head. “Only a Gatekeeper like you, or an old relic like me, still knows about it.”

“And what about the ‘last Queen’s Guard Corps’?” Agatha asked. “Why did you suddenly bring that up?”

“The last Queen’s Guard Corps was the unit that refused to surrender even after the rebels broke into the Queen’s palace. They used the city’s underground systems to fight on to the end,” Bishop Ivan said in a low voice, as if sunk in memory. “Their final stand was at the entrance to the Second Waterway. After that, they blew up all the connecting shafts and

were buried underground. The reason I mention this today… is that I suddenly remembered a rumor from that time."

Agatha's expression grew serious at once: "A rumor?"

"It is said that when the shafts were blown up, the soldiers who were attacking underground suddenly heard strange sounds from deep below. In the ground that had already fully collapsed, the last Queen's Guard Corps suddenly began to shout, as if charging at someone," Bishop Ivan recalled slowly. "For a long time after that, people often reported hearing shouts and charges from deep under the city. In the end, a rumor took shape. It said the 'last Queen's Guard Corps' had turned into a mutated legion in the depths. Every day they fought in the dark with boiling rage in their hearts. They were only waiting for the moment when the New Order, built by traitors, became most fragile. Then they would pour out from underground and settle the old accounts…"

Agatha's face grew grim: "The New Order's most fragile moment… Just now you said we are facing a crisis beyond understanding, and the city feels like it did fifty years ago. Do you mean this is the most fragile moment? That legendary Queen's Guard Corps will pour out from underground? Do you think that rumor is true?"

"I do not believe that rumor. The Queen's Guard Corps was wiped out long ago. I saw it with my own eyes. Even if…" Bishop Ivan stopped for a moment, as if something had come to mind, then shook his head. "Even if a few survivors did live for a time in the Second Waterway back then, they could not have lived to this day. A handful of living descendants would not be able to shake the rule of the city-state, even in the crisis we face now."

Agatha did not speak for a moment. After more than ten seconds of silence, she suddenly said: "The legend of the 'last Queen's Guard Corps' may be false. But it is true that there are large uncontrolled zones under Frostholm.

What you fear is not the Guard Corps that vanished fifty years ago, but something else hiding in the Second Waterway?”

“We have been searching the whole city for a long time. We have caught quite a few Annihilators, but they are all small fry, and most do not have strong hiding skills,” Bishop Ivan said with a nod. “There is no way they alone could have created so many ‘replicas’, so much ‘elements’ and ‘corruption’ in the city, much less caused the disturbance on Dagger Island. Now it seems the ones we caught are more like stragglers leaking out of a large nest. By now, most parts of the city have been searched more than once. If there is any place we have not checked… it can only be the depths underground.”

Agatha thought for a moment and then said, not very sure: “But records say that most sections of the Second Waterway have collapsed badly. The tunnels are cut off from each other and form a dead web of passages. On top of that, there are toxic ‘corruption’ substances and wide areas of darkness. It should be impossible to live down there. Annihilators are still living people. Aside from the few priests who are turning themselves into Abyssal Demons, most of them still need the normal living conditions of Humans… How could they stay hidden in such a place for long?”

“We should at least look,” Bishop Ivan said slowly. “Start with the collapse points around the Boiling Gold mines.”

Agatha thought it over and nodded slightly: “Then we will need City Hall to cooperate. Protective gear, underground machines, professional engineers… the great Cathedral does not have these things in stock.”

“I will talk to them,” Bishop Ivan said with a nod. “Make a list of the people and equipment you need. I can find a way to get them for you.”

“All right. I will give you the list before noon,” Agatha said without holding back. “Before the people and supplies are in place, I need to have a good

‘talk’ with the Annihilators we have already caught and see if they can cough up anything useful…”

…

As night faded and the sky grew lighter, Vision 001 began to rise from the edge of the city-state. The splendid Sun Wheel climbed into the sky bit by bit. The double rune rings swept over the tall spires and roofs. sunlight brought warmth and drove away the cold that had built up through the night.

At the gate of Cemetery No. 3, the heavy carved iron gate creaked open. As it swung, it swept the snow on the ground and left two arcs like spread wings. The Old Caretaker, wrapped in a worn coat, stood in front of the open gate. He took a deep breath and looked at the now clear sky.

The sky was clear, but for some reason even this bright morning did not calm the restlessness in his heart. The Old Caretaker looked toward the city streets. The distant sound of carts and horses reached his ears, faint yet noisy, like the uneasy wind from last night.

Even the clear sky now looked almost fake to him.

He muttered a few complaints under his breath, then looked toward the slope before the cemetery.

The wrinkles on the old man’s face relaxed a little. But the next second, they all twisted back again, and his brow furrowed tight.

He had seen a small figure appear on the slope, trudging up toward him with great effort and energy. When the figure noticed his gaze, it even stopped on purpose and waved happily in his direction.

The Old Caretaker’s face went stiff.

He waited for her to come closer. Only when Annie began brushing the snow from her pants and boots did he speak, looking displeased: “You again. I had a whole quiet day yesterday and thought you were finally going to stay home for once. And now here you are again?”

Annie stuck out her tongue: “I wanted to come yesterday too, but Mother said there was too much snow on the road. She said we had to wait until the snowplows cleared the main street before going out…”

She did not wait for the old man to answer. She took out a small bag with practiced ease and held it out: “Biscuits!”

“…I eat biscuits every day now,” the old man said. He glanced at what she offered, his eyelid twitching, but still reached out to take it. “Thank Lady Belloni for me.”

Annie laughed happily.

The Old Caretaker gave the girl a sideways look: “Anything else? The cemetery is not open for visits today.”

“Nothing. I just want to talk to you,” Annie said with a grin. “Do you know? We have some new guests staying in our house. Guess who they are?”

A twelve-year-old child was really not good at holding back a secret.

“I am not interested,” the Old Caretaker said, feeling baffled. He waved his hand impatiently. “The house is yours. You can rent it to whoever you want. What does that have to do with me?”

“It is that tall uncle wrapped in lots of bandages and dressed in black!” Annie did not mind the old man’s answer. Her smile grew even brighter, and her tone held a strange pride. “The one who was at the cemetery gate last time… Grandpa Caretaker, are you all right?”

Chapter 366: A Case

Annie left in high spirits. She looked as if she did not suspect anything at all – in the end, Annie was only a small child.

The Old Caretaker stood at the cemetery gate for a long time, staring in the direction Annie had gone. Only after who-knew-how-long did he suddenly shiver and come back to himself. His fingers trembled slightly as he reached to the pocket on his chest, took out a vial of medicine, and poured it into his mouth.

He felt much better.

“This matter is far too strange… I must report to the Cathedral at once… God of Death above… this matter is far too strange…”

The old man muttered under his breath, then turned and hurried toward the Warden’s hut. After he went inside and shut the door, he went straight to the old, ordinary-looking desk beside the bed. When he opened a hinged panel on the desktop, an intricate set of pipes and valves appeared underneath, along with buttons and levers.

Several metal capsule chambers lay quietly in a compartment beside the pipes.

The old man took a sheet of stationery from the desk drawer, sat down, picked up the fountain pen at hand, and began to write a report at great speed. Then he rolled the report up and stuffed it into a Metal Capsule Cartridge. After that, he opened a section of pipe hidden in the desk, and set the capsule into a slot.

“May Bartok bless this pipeline and the air rushing through it… may the valves run smoothly, without jamming, losing pressure, or exploding – and may the sorting and dispatch center’s Sorting Engine make no mistake.”

The old man finished this brief benediction, then pressed a button beside the pneumatic tube line. When the green light inside the hidden compartment lit up, he pulled the lever beside the button.

A strange gurgling sound came from deep inside the pipes, like air being blocked. But the sound faded quickly. The normal hissing of the pneumatic tube line, and the faint whoosh of the capsule racing along inside, followed right after.

The old man glanced at the pipe with some concern and muttered: “… surely it’s not because the letter mentioned a Higher Being and that somehow affected the machine…”

After a while, two green lights lit up, showing that the express dispatch had reached the higher sorting center. Only then did the Old Caretaker finally relax and close the cover of the hidden compartment.

…

Alice walked down the street with a large paper bag in her arms, looking curiously at the buildings around her. She studied this city that was completely different from Pland, and watched how people here lived.

In the paper bag were the things she had just bought from the corner shop – some vegetables, eggs, a block of rock-hard frozen butter, and two pieces of mutton. They were the ingredients for today’s lunch.

Alice could already go out and buy things on her own. She was not very skilled, and sometimes she got the change wrong, but she was working hard to learn all of this – she made progress every day, even if it was not much.

She lowered her head a little. One arm held the paper bag, and with her other hand she felt inside and pulled out a slip of paper to check what was written there.

Crooked letters covered the slip. It was today's shopping list. Part of it was written in words she already knew how to read and write. The rest was made up of simple little drawings. She had written the list herself, and it had taken a lot of effort.

She planned her own menu for each day, decided what ingredients she needed, wrote her own shopping list, and went to the shop herself. She tried to calculate the change correctly, and tried to get home on time. If she managed all that, the captain would be pleased.

Alice would be pleased too.

After making sure the list and the contents of the bag matched, the Doll put the slip away, satisfied, and went on toward their temporary lodgings on Oak Street.

But when she was only halfway there, a burst of commotion from a street corner suddenly drew her attention.

She raised her head toward the noise and saw a dozen or so people gathered beside an old-looking residential building. Some of them were pointing up at the upper floors. Everyone was talking at once, and she caught words like "that woman is crazy", "poor thing", and "even the Church is alarmed".

Alice could not help slowing her steps, slower and slower, until she finally stopped, staring toward that direction with great hesitation.

That was… a lively scene. The captain had said she must not rush into lively crowds, because if her head fell off in a place full of people, the commotion would be far too big.

But things over there really did look interesting. And what they were talking about… also sounded like something the captain would be interested in.

Alice struggled with herself, and, while struggling, she shuffled a little closer. Then a little closer again.

[I'll just go see what's going on… I'm helping the captain collect information… this isn't idly joining a crowd, this is very serious crowd-joining…]

Alice used all her wisdom to talk herself into it, and she succeeded.

One hand pressed on her head and the other held the paper bag. The Doll soon squeezed in beside the gathered crowd and joined them in looking up at the residential building in front of them.

Unlike the small two-story house the captain had rented, this building was even older and more cramped. The narrow windows and the gas pipes clinging to the outside wall looked crowded and messy. It seemed that many separate tenants lived inside this structure.

The people around her were all talking at once. Alice listened for a long time and still did not understand what was going on, so she carefully tapped the shoulder of the person next to her and asked very politely: "Excuse me… what happened here?"

The person beside her jumped in fright. But when he saw the speaker was only a veiled young lady, he relaxed, pointed up, and said: "A woman went crazy. She insists she killed her own husband, and she even tried to strangle her own child… first the Constables were alarmed, and now even people from the Church are here. I think this is no small matter."

As soon as he finished, another person next to them spoke up: "Since even the Church is here… maybe it really is something not very good?"

“…Let’s hope nothing major happens,” a woman in the crowd muttered. “I live right below them. If something really happens, we’ll have nowhere to go…”

“No matter what it is, we should go to the Cathedral today and have a priest perform an exorcism. It’s always better to be careful.”

The crowd started talking over each other again, and soon the topic drifted back into things Alice could not understand. Her mind wandered among the noisy voices, and her gaze slowly drifted up into the air.

Weightless strands floated in her vision. More thin threads stretched out from the nearby residential building, drifting in the air like hair in the wind, quietly stirring the sky.

Alice suddenly blinked.

She had just noticed that some of the lines floating above the city looked especially unreal and transparent. They even flickered like electric lamps with a bad connection.

…

A faint smell of mildew hung in the old residential building. Somewhere in the worn-out pipe system there was a small leak, and the sound of dripping water reached the ears from time to time. Black-clad Guardians, holding Gatekeeper’s canes and consecrated lanterns, crowded into the living room and made the already narrow space feel even more cramped.

A long-haired woman with tangled hair curled up in the corner of the sofa like a frightened animal. She lowered her head and sometimes muttered unclear sentences.

Two Guardians stood beside her, closely watching over this woman whose mind had lost its balance.

The Guardians were searching the house for lingering clues. They had already been working here for two hours.

Just then, a gust of Ashen Wind blew down the corridor, passed through the open front door, and spun into the living room.

The Guardians all stopped what they were doing and bowed to the gray-white whirlwind.

Agatha stepped out of the vortex and into the room. Her gaze swept across the living room.

“How is the situation now?” She lifted her head and looked toward the highest-ranking Guardian at the scene.

The captain of the Guardians was a sharp-looking woman with black, ear-length hair. Faced with the Gatekeeper’s question, she stepped forward at once and said: “We collected a small amount of ‘mud’ from the floor in the washroom. We have confirmed that it matches the samples we collected before.”

“elements…” Agatha said softly, then frowned. “A small amount? How much? Is that all?”

“About one test tube,” the short-haired captain said, lifting her hand to show the rough amount. “That is all of it. We have searched the whole building from top to bottom. Only a little remained on the washroom floor.”

Agatha fell silent for a moment, then turned her head to look at the long-haired woman curled in the corner of the sofa.

“She is the one involved?”

“Yes,” the Squad Captain said with a nod. “She rents this place. We checked her history. Her background is clean and she has no criminal record. She works as an assistant accountant at an office nearby. Her husband used to

work in the Boiling Gold Mine. Records show he died in a mining accident three years ago.”

Boiling Gold Mine… a mining accident…

Maybe because of recent events, those words drew Agatha’s notice at once. She steadied herself, then walked over to the woman who was still muttering on the sofa.

“Lady – I am the city-state’s Gatekeeper. You are safe now,” Agatha said in a calm, deep voice, quietly calling on her power to soothe the mind. “Tell me, what exactly happened?”

The long-haired woman stopped trembling when she heard the voice. She mumbled something under her breath, then suddenly lifted her head.

A pair of bloodshot eyes, still full of fear and madness, locked onto Agatha.

“He came back, he came back… I killed him, I killed that monster… in the bathroom! It melted in the bathroom!”

Chapter 367: The Shelter Left Behind

Those eyes were bloodshot, and inside them madness and terror surged, impossible to fully suppress. Even though the Gatekeeper's words had soothed the woman's mind and pulled her back from the edge of collapse, they could not smooth away the Shadows fear had left in her thoughts.

Agatha had seen that kind of gaze many times. She simply met it calmly, using her own eyes to help the woman settle a little more before she spoke: "The 'he' you just mentioned – you mean your husband, do you not? He returned home again. But you know he died several years ago."

The woman's shoulders shook hard. She lowered her head and clutched her own hair, as if she did not dare look Agatha in the face. She only repeated over and over: "He came back… he came back… but I knew it wasn't him…"

"How did you kill 'it'?" Agatha frowned slightly. "Do you still remember the details?"

As she spoke, she reached into her coat and took out a small vial of potion. She opened the cap with one hand, and a scent that calmed the mind slowly spread out, filling the air around them.

The Gatekeeper's potion began to work. The long-haired woman's breathing grew much steadier. She raised her head a little and peered out through strands of her hair. Her voice was very low: "I… I hit the back of that thing's head with a hammer from behind, and then it fell down. But

even though the back of its head caved in so much, it didn't die. It struggled and got up again. I kicked it farther inside and then shut the bathroom door… it knocked on the door and let out horrible shouts. It was early in the morning. It screamed for ten minutes before it stopped…"

The woman fell silent, then took a few seconds to steady herself before she went on: "Later, I quietly opened a crack in the bathroom door… and that thing was gone…"

Agatha nodded lightly. In her mind, she pieced together what had happened while she asked her next question: "Then how did 'it' appear? Do you remember how he 'came back'?"

"I… I don't know," the woman said, shaking her head in fright. "He… it suddenly appeared at home. The front door was locked, but I heard sounds in the living room. I came out from the bedroom and saw that thing… it was wearing the clothes my husband had on when he was buried, walking back and forth in the living room. There was a sound in its body, like rotting slime moving around…"

Agatha's expression grew serious. She turned her head, and before she could even speak, a Guardian nearby reported: "We have already checked the entrances to the house. None of the doors or windows show any sign of forced entry, and every window is locked from the inside."

The doors and windows were sealed. The locks were untouched. The replica had simply appeared in the resident's home.

Compared with open "invasion" or "attack", this kind of thing that seemed to appear from thin air made Agatha even more alert.

And today's case had more to worry about than that.

Agatha lowered her head and looked at the woman on the sofa again.

She remembered the cases she had handled in the days before this one, especially the one at 42 Fireplace Street – the folklore Scholar who studied the return of the dead, and the female apprentice who had suffered severe cognitive corruption without even realising it. In such classic cases, the survivors had been completely unable to tell that the “replica” in front of them was not the real person.

But this woman had seen through it.

She had not been affected by cognitive corruption?

“Lady,” Agatha said at last, choosing her words with care, “how did you realize that ‘monster’ was not your husband?”

“Do you even need to ask? My husband… he died years ago. That thing was wrong in every way. How could it be my husband?” The woman grew excited. “Besides… besides, that thing walked toward my child… my child. He pointed at that monster and called it dad. He… he was being controlled by that monster. It must have controlled my child. He…”

“You believed your child was being controlled by a monster, so you grabbed him by the neck?” Agatha’s brow drew together again. “Do you understand that at the time you…”

“I didn’t grab his neck! I was just trying to pull him back, I didn’t grab him!”

The woman became completely agitated. She even jumped up from the sofa as if she were about to pounce at the Gatekeeper. The blood in her eyes flooded back, and the same fear and madness returned so strongly that her reason seemed to vanish. The Guardians nearby reacted at once and moved to restrain the poor woman who had lost her sanity, but Agatha was faster.

The Gatekeeper lifted her Gatekeeper’s cane and lightly tapped the woman’s forehead.

The woman fell asleep on the spot.

“She is terrified,” the black-haired captain said, shaking her head. “For an ordinary person, something like this really is…”

“No. It isn’t simple fright. It is another form of sanity corruption. She is in a temporary state of madness and has only kept the most basic ability to talk,” Agatha said, still shaking her head. Her brow remained tightly furrowed. “She has not been affected by cognitive and memory interference. We do not yet know the exact reason, but she clearly saw the true nature of that ‘replica’. For an ordinary person, ‘seeing the truth’ itself is a kind of damage.”

As she spoke, she raised her head and looked around this small dwelling.

“Where is the child?”

“He has been taken to a safe place for now,” the captain replied. “He was badly frightened and also suffered brief suffocation. He may not be able to answer questions.”

“Good,” Agatha said. “Keep the mother and child apart for the time being. Make sure they are under proper watch and get mental support, especially the child. Comfort him. If either of them remembers any useful information, report to me at once.”

“Yes.”

Agatha nodded, then walked through the living room into the small washroom that also served as a bathroom.

Marks left by the Guardians’ forensic work were still visible on the floor near the shower head.

The replica had once been locked in this bathroom. In the end, though, it had left behind less than a single test tube of “sample”.

That was very strange.

replicas might be mysterious in nature and their origins might be unknown, but at least one thing was clear: they were made of a certain amount of physical matter. Even if they broke apart, that material would not simply vanish into nothing.

Agatha frowned and paced twice around the cramped washroom. Suddenly she stopped, her gaze fixed on one spot.

In the corner, at the opening of a rusted drainpipe.

She moved quickly to the drain, tapped the cast-iron grate with the tip of her tin Gatekeeper's cane, and stared down into the dark hole.

The darkness inside the pipe had no visible end, as if it buried all truths.

"…No way… damn it."

Agatha drew in a sharp breath. She had just realized a possibility, and that possibility made her hands and feet go cold.

"Evacuate this building. Move all residents to the Cathedral in this district and to the public shelters nearby," she said as she hurried back into the living room, speaking at great speed. "Contact the district municipal office. Close off this building… no, close all secondary pipelines connected to this building, including both sewage and water lines. Send a team immediately to the nearest sewage treatment plant to check the settling tanks and filters."

The Squad Captain was startled by this string of orders, but she did not ask any questions. Her training to obey orders took over at once, and she snapped to attention: "Yes, Lady Gatekeeper!"

After finishing her orders, Agatha walked back to the sofa where the sleeping woman lay.

Why had this woman not been affected by cognitive and memory interference, and instead seen the truth of the “replica”?

Even now, Agatha cared very much about this question.

At that moment, a Guardian who had been searching other rooms suddenly ran into the living room, holding something in both hands.

“Lady Gatekeeper! We found this!”

Agatha turned at once. She saw that the Guardian was holding a small plaster statue that looked quite old.

It was a profile bust of the Frostholm Queen.

“A statue of the mad Queen?” another Guardian whispered at once. “I did not expect to see one here.”

Agatha’s expression grew solemn. She stepped forward and took the bust, which was a little over ten centimeters tall, then carefully examined the details.

“It is a genuine piece from back then. There is a special anti-counterfeit mark on the base,” she said after a brief check, then raised her head. “Where was this placed?”

“In a hidden compartment at the back of a closet,” the Guardian who had found it reported at once. “We also found coins from the Queen’s era and a commemorative album. It seems someone here is still secretly remembering the Frostholm Queen.”

Agatha did not speak for a while. She only stared at the plaster bust in her hands.

Frostholm Queen… even half a century later, there were still citizens in the city-state who secretly remembered the Queen. That fact itself did not surprise her.

That had been a glorious age, and she had been a great Queen. Fifty short years were not enough to erase every trace of the Queen's era from the city-state. Some old people who had lived through that time, and their children and grandchildren, were still deeply marked by it.

There were, here and there among the people, a few who still supported the Queen. Fifty years ago, such secret acts of remembrance would have been enough to earn a hanging. Today, however, the bans in this area had grown much looser. During her years as Gatekeeper, Agatha had heard of such things more than once.

In most cases, when it was only a private "collection of memorial items", today's Guardians and Constables would not pursue it too harshly. Sometimes they even pretended not to see, or only gave a verbal warning.

This family had only collected a bust of the Queen, a few coins, and an album. That alone was not anything serious.

But when she linked it to the strange event that had just taken place in this home, Agatha could not help thinking more deeply.

In this case, the person involved had not been affected by cognitive interference. Instead, she had seen through the truth of the "replica". Could it be… connected to these Queen relics left in this house?

Chapter 368: Chance Encounter and Reunion

Agatha checked the hidden compartment that held the Queen's profile statue. It was just as her subordinate had reported—it was only a private spot for secretly commemorating the Frostholm Queen, with no trace of any supernatural power left behind.

She looked at the things that had been taken out: the plaster statue, the commemorative coins, and the booklet.

Fifty years ago, this would have been worth a noose.

But that terrifying era that kept everyone's nerves taut had already passed. The Frostholm authorities now had to think about the city-state's long-term stability and their own image of fairness. They could not launch a big purge just because of secret public acts of remembrance. These harmless commemorations usually only earned a warning now, at most a fine.

And even warnings and fines were matters for the constables—the secular regulations and laws were not the Cathedral's responsibility.

"This is not something we should interfere with," Agatha shook her head. "Sort out this part of the situation and notify the public security authority. Let them handle the follow-up. But we need to take these souvenirs back and examine them, in case something… is hidden inside."

"Yes."

After she gave a few more simple instructions for wrapping up the scene, Agatha rose from the sofa and let out a quiet breath.

There were too many matters waiting to be handled. She could not keep wasting time here.

“Remember to keep tracking the investigation at the sewage treatment center and to monitor the pipe system in this area at all times,” she told her subordinate at last, then turned and walked out of the room.

Outside was a narrow corridor. The old staircase stretched forward under dim lights. Two other households had quietly opened their doors, peeking at the commotion here, several pairs of slightly panicked eyes watching from the crack.

Agatha waved at those eyes.

“Go back inside, pack a few things, and wait for instructions. This area needs to be evacuated for a while. Don’t worry, we will solve the problem here as soon as possible. You will be able to come home again very soon.”

After saying this, Agatha did not bother about the residents’ reactions. She started down the stairs toward the exit on the first floor.

She did not use Ashen Wind to hurry along, even though she usually liked doing that. Today her thoughts were in a mess. All kinds of tangled matters filled her mind. She felt she needed to sort them out, and walking slowly would help her think.

At the same time, she also wanted to sense the traces left in this whole building, to see if she could detect any other spots stained with elements corruption.

Lost in thought, she walked down the old stairs to the exit and stepped out into the open space in front of the residential building.

The stale, moldy smell vanished at once. The fresh, icy air lifted Agatha's spirits. For a moment she even felt an illusion—as if she had just walked out of some dark, damp burrow and into the sunlight.

The crowd that had gathered in front of the residential building had already scattered. Only a few curious passersby lingered at a safe distance, pointing and whispering. When Agatha appeared, those onlookers quickly left as well.

No. Someone was still here.

Agatha frowned. She saw a young woman with long blond hair and a veil over her face, clutching a large bag in her arms, still standing in the open space in front of the building. She looked like she was spacing out.

"This area is sealed off. Please do not linger," Agatha walked over and reminded her in a slightly stern tone. "Are you a resident here?"

The veiled blonde seemed startled, jolted awake, and turned to look at Agatha. She pointed at herself in confusion: "Are you talking to me?"

"Of course. Who else is here?" Agatha frowned. For some reason, she could not help paying attention to this stranger. She was sure she had never met the woman, yet her features looked a bit familiar, as if Agatha had just seen her not long ago. "Are you a resident here?"

"Ah, no, no," Alice quickly waved her hands and pointed into the distance. "I live over there, pretty far away. What happened here? I heard someone died?"

"The Guardians are handling it," Agatha said casually, still puzzled. The blonde woman's reaction was a bit odd. Had she really not recognized the city-state's Gatekeeper standing in front of her?

Alice, however, did not notice any change in the eyes of the black-clad, bandage-wrapped woman before her. She only thought this outfit looked

very interesting.

It looked a lot like how the captain dressed now.

But the captain had told her not to comment lightly on other people's appearance, and not to say too much about herself to strangers—the first was not polite, and the second was not cautious.

Alice still could not spell those two words, but she felt sure the captain was right.

It was time to say goodbye.

So she waved at Agatha and said in a cheerful tone: "Then I'll be going! Thank you for answering my questions!"

The veiled blonde left just like that, looking delighted, but Agatha felt only strangeness as she watched her back.

What was this person even here for?

She had lived in this city-state for more than twenty years, yet she had never seen anyone like that—someone who radiated a simple, nameless happiness from head to toe, who spoke with no wariness at all, whose smile held not the slightest shadow.

Agatha frowned, then suddenly froze. It was as if she only noticed some odd detail after the other woman had already left.

"No breathing or heartbeat…?!"

The young Gatekeeper jerked her head up and looked toward the direction the blonde had gone. She moved to chase her almost without thinking, but just as she was about to step forward, a flurry of hurried footsteps suddenly interrupted her.

A black-clad guard came running over, holding up a sheet of intelligence. His expression looked quite anxious.

“What is it?” Agatha asked sharply before he could speak, frowning. In her heart she could not help muttering—things were chaotic enough already. Please, let nothing else happen.

“An urgent express dispatch from Cemetery No. 3,” the guard said, straightening up and speaking very quickly. “A clue about the mysterious ‘Visitor’. This is the original report.”

Agatha’s breathing clearly stopped for a beat. Then she snatched the letter from his hand, shook it open with one motion, and let her eyes race across the words.

The young Gatekeeper fell silent. She stood there without moving, frozen in place, not reacting for a long time.

The guard looked at his direct superior with some concern. After a few seconds, he could not help speaking up: “Gatekeeper, this matter…”

Agatha slowly turned her head and looked into her subordinate’s eyes: “If someone suddenly told you that a being comparable to the Elder Gods had descended to the city-state in person, and that the way He walks the mortal world is by going to the citizen Assistance Center and renting a two-story house with a terrace… how would you react?”

“…I would go to the nearest Cathedral for some counseling, or find a well-known psychiatrist,” the guard answered honestly.

“You are not wrong. Unfortunately, I am already the highest-ranked representative of the Cathedral in this city-state, and psychiatrists cannot solve the problem of an Elder God descending,” Agatha sighed, slowly folding the letter away. “Every single matter is important. Every single matter’s priority has to be at the very front… ah.”

She lifted her head and looked toward the place mentioned in the report—Oak Street.

It happened to be in the direction where that strange blonde woman with no breath or heartbeat had gone.

…

Nina ran excitedly around the whole house, then darted into the kitchen to examine the cookware, which was clearly much better than anything they had at home in Pland.

Shirley and Dog wandered all over the living room and dining room on the first floor, pretending to “inspect” the place. Whenever they stopped, they had to comment on the furnishings around them.

They had been stuck on the Vanished for so long that they were about to burst.

Ai perched on the nearby dining table, its whole body buried in a huge pile of fries. Today was its great feast day.

Duncan sat on the sofa in the living room, watching all this with a smile. All his smiles were hidden behind thick bandages, but Vanna, standing beside him, suddenly had a strange feeling… At this moment, Captain Duncan’s eyes looked like those of a kind old father.

Vanna quickly shook her head and pushed that ridiculous thought aside. She looked at the two young ladies running all over the house (and the dog).

“There is an empty room upstairs reserved for you two. Did you go look at it?”

“We did, we did!” Nina trotted over, nodding again and again. “It’s great. It’s even a bit bigger than my room back in Pland!”

“This place is really not bad,” Shirley ran over too, her smile extra bright. “If I’d known you were settled this well in the city-state, I would have come over two days ago. It’s so boring on the ship! There’s nothing to do every day…”

Duncan slowly turned his head: “The homework I leave you every day is enough to keep you busy for three hours. How could you have nothing to do?”

Shirley instantly realized she had said the wrong thing and shrank her neck at once.

“You wrote it for her?” Duncan lowered his head a little and looked at Dog, who was trying hard to hide in the Shadows.

Dog’s head almost disappeared into his shoulders: “I… I was just practicing more for myself, so I wouldn’t waste your hard work teaching me…”

Duncan laughed out loud, sounding truly pleased.

“Relax. I brought you here to have fun, not just to scold you,” he waved a hand, then looked up at the Chronometer Clock on the wall. “Alice will be back soon. There is at least an hour before dinner. Shirley… make up some homework. Start from page sixteen of the vocabulary book.”

Shirley’s wail rang in Vanna and Morris’s ears for the first time in a long while.

Chapter 369: The Gatekeeper Pays a Visit

Duncan sat on the sofa in the living room, relaxed, reading the morning newspaper he had bought on the street. From time to time he turned his head to glance at Shirley, who was hunched over the coffee table, frowning as she wrote, and at Dog, who lay beside her, fully absorbed in a copy of *Abridged Modern History of the City-States*. The sight filled him with a quiet sense of peace.

In this strange and eerie world, he had finally found a bit of familiar rhythm again.

On the other hand, bringing Dog, Shirley, and Nina over also fulfilled an idea he had been turning over in his mind for a long time—Captain Duncan's little classroom had finally reopened.

He turned his head to the other side of the coffee table. Nina had pulled over a small stool and sat there, carefully working on her winter break homework. Morris sat beside her, supervising, occasionally correcting some small mistakes for his student.

"You are a responsible teacher," Duncan said to Morris. "Nina is lucky."

"She is a hardworking child. I don't want to delay her life," Morris smiled. Then he glanced at the homework spread in front of Shirley, and his expression grew a little complicated. "But I did not expect you to be so good at… teaching others."

Duncan raised an eyebrow: “Oh?”

“The study plan you set for Shirley, Alice, and Dog is very reasonable, even… somewhat professional,” Morris said, sounding a bit hesitant. “I also saw the test papers you prepared for them earlier. They were quite professional as well. That was a bit… beyond what I expected.”

The old mister chose his words very carefully. He really did care about this. When he first heard that Duncan was enthusiastically going to teach the three illiterates on the ship how to read, the picture in his mind was not vocabulary cards, vocabulary books, and multiplication tables. The first image that surfaced went straight toward Eldritch God retainers gathering on a ritual field to touch forbidden knowledge. Yet what he actually saw was the fearsome Captain Duncan pulling out a stack of literacy cards…

How to put it… He had more or less grown used to Captain Duncan’s mild, friendly manner in private now. But whenever he thought about a being from the Subspace Shadows seriously giving people lessons—literacy lessons, at that—that awkward feeling still surged up uncontrollably.

Duncan of course understood what the old scholar meant, but he had no way to explain. He only smiled and waved a hand: “Perhaps I once had a dream of being a teacher.”

Morris did not know what to say for a moment. Duncan leaned over to glance at Shirley’s maddening handwriting and could not help sighing: “It is a shame the progress of these three students is so uneven. It is really a headache.”

Morris thought for a bit and nodded: “Indeed. I feel Dog could almost camp out in some library and teach himself all the way to graduation now, yet Shirley is still wrestling with common vocabulary. Alice… Alice, she…”

Duncan sighed again: “Ah, Alice works very hard, but she is Alice.”

The learning progress of the three illiterates on the ship was nothing like what he had imagined at first. He had thought that, since she had a sharper mind, Shirley's pace would be faster, yet she was still half illiterate. Her unwavering determination to slack off and her despairing attitude toward study were the main reasons. Alice, on the other hand, worked harder than anyone, but the doll miss's head simply did not seem suited for reading and writing. In the end, the most advanced of the three illiterates turned out to be a dog. With astonishing diligence and understanding, Dog could not only read literary works on his own now, he could even solve three-variable quadratic equations…

There were countless Abyssal Hounds chasing after knowledge—now it seemed only Dog had actually caught up.

To be fair, this was the greatest stain on Duncan—or rather Zhou Ming's—entire teaching career.

Just as he was thinking this, Alice, who had gone out to buy groceries, finally came back—almost twenty minutes later than expected.

"I'm back!"

The doll miss opened the door and stepped inside. As she put down the things in her hands, she craned her neck toward the living room and called out. With one glance she saw the study ace, the study slacker, and the study dog doing homework by the coffee table, and her face lit up with delight: "Nina! Shirley! Dog! You're here?"

"We came this morning. I've already been doing this damn… already been making up homework for half the day…" Shirley lifted her head, eyes brimming. "The captain said I have to copy everything from page sixteen in the vocabulary book onward all over again…"

“Three times,” Duncan said calmly from the side. “Don’t quietly trim two-thirds off your own assignment.”

Then he ignored Shirley’s reaction and looked up at Alice: “Why are you only back now? Did you run into trouble?”

“Ah, no, no!” Alice waved both hands quickly. “There was just some commotion… I didn’t go watch the commotion! Something happened, and I investigated it…”

This doll truly could not lie and was not good at making excuses. In just a few sentences she exposed the fact that she had wasted time watching the commotion on her way home.

“Investigated?” Duncan looked at Alice with mild surprise. He did not intend to pursue the matter of her “watching the commotion”, even though he had indeed warned her not to wander around on the way. That was only a small thing. What he cared more about was… that the usually scatterbrained Alice had just said the word “investigated” with such a serious expression.

Even if it was just an excuse she had made up on the spot, he still cared a great deal about what this doll had gone to investigate.

“On that street nearby, there was a household where they said someone had died. People from the Church had all gone over,” Alice immediately began telling Duncan what she had seen on the way. “A woman said she killed her husband, and the onlookers were saying the man of the house had gone out before that or something… Ah, right, right, I also saw a woman whose clothes looked a lot like yours! She was wrapped in bandages too…”

Duncan listened, a bit dazed, to the doll’s rambling, point-less story and barely managed to figure out what had happened. Then he noticed the last part, about the “bandaged woman”. He frowned slightly and was just about

to ask for details when he saw Vanna, who had been feeding the pigeons at the dining table, suddenly stand up.

“Stranger approaching,” Vanna said quickly. “Clergy.”

Duncan immediately waved his hand, signaling Alice to be quiet and put her veil back on. Dog, who had been squatting by the sofa, slipped back into the Shadows in the blink of an eye. Ai flapped its wings and hid on a nearby cabinet. Morris rose from the sofa and went to the door.

“Don’t be nervous. It is only a guest,” Duncan remained quite calm. He waved at the somewhat tense Vanna and Morris, then walked to the door and pulled it open.

A young woman in a long black coat, bandages wrapped around her body, wearing a black round hat and holding a Gatekeeper’s cane, stood outside. Her hand was still raised, ready to knock.

She seemed frozen in place.

Duncan looked the young lady up and down, then glanced down at himself.

“Ah, matching outfits,” he said casually.

“That’s her, that’s her,” Alice, standing slightly behind Duncan, saw the visitor clearly now and eagerly leaned over. “The black-clothed woman I told you about, the one I saw on the way back from buying groceries…”

Alice’s voice jolted Agatha out of her daze. The muscles on her face twitched slightly. It took her quite an effort to drag her gaze away from the tall, broad figure before her and look toward the source of the sound.

The blonde woman with no breath or heartbeat, whom she had met not long ago, now stood inside the house, watching with curious, delighted eyes.

She really was here.

Agatha took several deep breaths, trying to calm her racing heart. The faint ringing in her head slowly faded. The darkness and double vision that came from suddenly staring into the Truth finally retreated from before her eyes. At last she let out a quiet breath. In her chaotic mind, she remembered why she had come.

A slightly stiff smile appeared on her face: “I… did not mean to disturb you. I only came to check on the situation. You…”

“Come in,” Duncan said calmly, nodding and stepping aside to open a path. “It is quite cold. Let’s not talk at the door.”

Agatha froze for a moment, not reacting at first.

Seeing this, Vanna, who had been silent before, could not help frowning. She stepped forward and looked at the newcomer: “You rushed over here knowing exactly what this place is. Don’t tell me you never thought about what would happen once the door opened?”

“Have some sympathy,” Morris said quickly at her side. “Anyone’s mind would be a mess the first time they met the captain. The higher your Spirit Sight, the worse it is. This young lady is clearly all tangled up.”

When Vanna heard this, she immediately recalled her own first day aboard the Vanished and decided the old mister was right.

While Vanna and Morris were talking, Agatha finally came back to herself. Her mind was still somewhat chaotic, but reason had taken control again. Thanks to Duncan’s deliberate restraint, her sanity had not been too badly shaken. As soon as she recovered, she hurriedly nodded: “Sorry, I was a bit distracted.”

Then she looked at the path Duncan had opened. After a brief hesitation, she finally stepped forward.

She knew what this place was.

She knew that the towering figure before her was, in essence, an indescribable being who had descended into the city-state, with a rank very likely comparable to the Elder Gods.

She knew that with this step, she was entering a “descent site”.

But from the moment the door had opened, there had been no room left for regret.

Behind Duncan, Morris watched the tense young lady step inside. He tilted his head slightly toward Vanna and whispered: “She’s a bit better than you were.”

Vanna muttered softly: “That wasn’t my fault. The captain’s first Dreamwalking was too terrifying.”

Morris nodded: “That’s true…”

Vanna added: “But the second time, I was much calmer.”

Listening to the two of them muttering behind him, Duncan finally could not help turning his head: “You weren’t much better the second time either. Quiet down. We have a guest.”

Chapter 370: Agatha Understood

Nervous and curious, Agatha quietly looked around the place.

It looked like a completely ordinary home. Most of the furniture seemed a bit old, but everything was tidy and clean. The air in the room was fresh, as if the windows had been opened not long ago to let the wind through. From the direction of the kitchen came the sound of water heating, like a kettle coming to a boil.

This did not look like a “descent site” at all. It was simply a normal residence.

Of course, Agatha knew from the start that this had originally been just an ordinary house. Until a few days ago, it had still been listed on the citizen Help Center’s register as a property for rent. She had only thought that… since an indescribable Visitor had chosen to make this his temporary residence, shouldn’t there be something special about it?

But she had not found anything.

“Tea? Or some coffee?” Duncan came over to Agatha’s side and asked casually.

Agatha jolted back to herself. She stared in surprise at Duncan, now sitting opposite her, and only after a heartbeat understood what he meant. She hurriedly waved her hand: “No… thank you, I’m not thirsty.”

“No need to be so tense. Just treat this like your own home,” Duncan smiled as he sat down on the sofa across from her, speaking in a relaxed tone. “Let

me think… If I’m not mistaken, you should be this city?state’s Gatekeeper? At a time like this, someone who comes knocking on the door is unlikely to be an ordinary Guardian.”

“Gatekeeper Agatha,” Agatha nodded at once, trying her best to look calm. “You knew I would come?”

“You were sure to come. If not you, then some other high?ranking member of the Church,” Duncan said lightly. “Annie will tell the Gravekeeper about me, and the Gravekeeper will report the situation to the Church. All I had to do was wait here to meet the upper ranks of this city?state’s Church.”

Agatha adjusted her posture a little and studied the burly figure before her with a more solemn gaze, as if trying to divine the truth: “I want to know… your real purpose. Who are you, really, and why have you come to Frostholm?”

“Didn’t I say already?” Duncan raised his eyebrows. “I came to solve the problems happening here. I thought I made that quite clear in the denunciation letter.”

Agatha opened her mouth, clearly still having trouble accepting such a simple answer. After two or three seconds, she spoke, hesitant: “Is it really… just that?”

“If you need a darker motive and a more complicated conspiracy before this feels reasonable, I can make one up on the spot,” Duncan said offhandedly. “What style do you like? world?ending Doomsday, or a monarch descending to conquer the world?”

Agatha’s body visibly tensed.

“Ahem, you scared her,” Vanna suddenly coughed twice behind Duncan. “This Gatekeeper will take you seriously.”

“Will she?” Duncan turned his head a little, puzzled. “I thought the joke was obvious…”

“In my experience, yes,” Vanna sighed helplessly. “In this line of work, people’s nerves are always tight. They can’t take jokes.”

For a moment Duncan did not know what to say. Agatha, meanwhile, looked in confusion at the extremely tall woman. Ever since she had entered the house, she had felt that woman’s eyes fall on her, intentionally or not, as if… as if Vanna was watching something with interest.

But that was not important. What mattered was that she had confirmed the Higher Being before her had only been joking with her—cruelly and in a very frightening way.

“Please forgive my sensitivity,” Agatha said sincerely. “Recently the Anomalies in the city?state have been growing more and more severe. Everyone’s nerves are on edge. I even, at one point, suspected…”

She hesitated and did not finish, but Duncan smoothly took over: “At one point you even suspected me? Don’t be so tense, that’s reasonable. My timing was a little too perfect, and the first time I came here I ended up dealing with Annihilators and ‘replicas’.”

Agatha did not answer. She only looked a bit embarrassed.

“I want to know how far your investigation has gone,” Duncan went on, not minding her reaction. “Any leads?”

Agatha hesitated, unsure whether she should reveal too much of Frostholm’s internal information to this Visitor of mysterious origin. After a moment, choosing her words, she spoke: “After we received your warning, we did capture some Annihilators, but we gained almost no useful information. Those heretics who formed deep symbiotic pacts with Deep Sea Demons have extremely strong minds and usually choose self?

destruction at the last moment. The few we took alive are all peripheral figures who know nothing about the full plan…

“Even now, all we can confirm is that the frequent replica phenomena in the city are indeed the work of those heretics, and that they have built a hidden and vast nest somewhere in Frostholm. As for the exact location of that nest… we still have no clue.”

She paused, then went on: “As for Dagger Island, which you mentioned in that letter… what is even more troubling is that it has already vanished.”

“I know,” Duncan said calmly.

“You already knew?” Agatha asked in surprise. “That news should still be sealed…”

“I have my own channels for information in the mortal world,” Duncan answered in the same light tone. “Even without leaving the city?state, I know some of what happens on the open sea.”

Those channels were, of course, Tyrian. After all, Dagger Island had vanished right in front of the Sea Mist Fleet, so Tyrian would naturally report it to the Vanished at once.

But even having learned this shocking news at the first moment, Duncan could only be shocked along with everyone else. He too had no idea how such a large island could simply vanish into thin air.

According to what Tyrian had reported, the island had not sunk so much as seemed to melt directly into the sea. Before it disappeared there had been a series of massive explosions, as if the people on the island had activated something. But beyond that, there was no further information.

Information was scarce. The way it vanished was far too strange, and it left behind no trace or clue. Dagger Island had gone from one riddle to an even

greater one. No one knew what had happened there, let alone where the island had gone.

“Do you know where Dagger Island went?” Agatha’s voice broke into Duncan’s thoughts. The city?state’s Gatekeeper raised her head and looked at him with sincere eyes. “Do you know what happened to it?”

Duncan thought for a moment. He felt that if he admitted he had pondered it for an entire night and still not figured it out, it might hurt his image. So he fell silent for a bit, then stretched out his hand and pointed toward the floor.

“Down?” Agatha froze for a second. “You mean Dagger Island really did sink into the sea… but the eyewitness reports said there were no whirlpools on the surface like when an island sinks…”

Duncan had no idea how to answer. He was just as curious how such a huge island could simply vanish!

So he simply kept his hand extended, still pointing at the floor.

“You don’t mean Dagger Island… You mean the clues are beneath our feet?” Agatha seemed to suddenly understand. Almost at once she recalled her most recent conversation with Bishop Ivan and remembered the matter of the “Second Waterway” deep underground!

City Hall and the Church had already searched the entire city?state. Strict curfews and repeated large?scale sweeps should, in theory, have been enough to root out many hidden cultists, yet the Annihilators they caught were always just a few marginal figures. Every place where people could hide—the First Waterway, the subway, service shafts—had already been searched, with no clues at all…

The city?state was only so big. If there were no traces of those heretics in any of the places above, then the Second Waterway was the only possibility left.

Those collapsed sections, those caves sunk in darkness, those shafts and pipes covered in corruption… They might indeed be unfit for living beings, but what if that group of Annihilators had really survived down there?

Of course, searching the Second Waterway had always been part of the plan. She had just never dared to confirm whether this search, which would demand such staggering resources, was truly worth it. Now, she had finally found the strongest support for that action—a friendly Quasi?Divine Being had plainly indicated that they had to look downward.

“So that’s it—I understand now. Our direction is correct,” Agatha suddenly stood up, her tone filled with sudden realization and joy. She looked at Duncan across from her. Her attitude became especially sincere and respectful, and she bowed deeply. “I understand now—thank you very much for your reminder!”

Duncan still kept his hand pointed at the floor, staring a little blankly at the bandaged woman who had suddenly become so excited.

[What did she just understand?]

“We will immediately start the next stage of the search. This time we will dig out those heretics’ nest by the roots,” Agatha said with full confidence, not noticing Duncan’s dazed look, and soon moved to take her leave. “Then I won’t waste your time any longer—excuse me for disturbing you this time, I will be going.”

“Uh… all right,” Duncan stood up half a beat late and said without thinking: “Take care on your way…”

Agatha thanked him, turned, and walked toward the door. Then she suddenly seemed to remember something and stopped.

Alice, who had been about to get up to see her off, almost bumped right into her.

Agatha's gaze swept over Alice, but this time she did not pay much attention to the blonde woman with no heartbeat or breath. For a Quasi? Divine Being, it was perfectly normal for followers at his side to be a little unusual. It was nothing to be shocked about.

She turned her head back toward Duncan.

"Please rest assured. I will order the Church's Guardians so that no one comes to disturb you," Agatha said very seriously. "I hope you can live comfortably in Frostholm. If there is any new development, I will come in person."

"Ah, that would be very good," Duncan laughed, quite pleased. "I really don't want anyone coming to bother me."

Agatha nodded and turned toward the door again. She had only taken two steps when she once more seemed to remember something and stopped.

"One more thing. I almost forgot." The Gatekeeper pressed her temple in some embarrassment and looked at Duncan as she spoke.

Duncan looked puzzled and said: "Oh?"

Agatha hesitated, then finally asked the question that had troubled her and many others for a long time: "About the 'Secret Cipher' you left at the end of that denunciation letter… what does it actually mean? Forgive our shallow wit. We have tried to decipher it for a long time and still cannot understand the riddle you left."

Duncan was silent for a moment, then said: "…Ah?"

Chapter 371: Anomaly Aura

When she reached the street, the icy wind swept through the open space between the buildings and blew against her face, bringing Agatha fully back to her senses.

Yet in her mind there still echoed that string of questions that had almost shattered her worldview and rebuilt her understanding—

“In Frostholm, you don’t give bonuses to helpful citizens who actively report cult clues?

“You never used a bank account? Do you people in the Church never deal with ordinary life?

“You didn’t see that was a bank account number?”

Agatha had never imagined that the biggest loss of composure she would ever suffer while dealing with an supernatural being would happen under circumstances like this.

And she was quite sure that Bishop Ivan of the Grand Cathedral, and that group of Cryptographers and Divination masters who were still gathered in the Cathedral desperately studying the ‘Secret Cipher’, would react almost the same way she had when they found out the truth.

Footsteps sounded nearby. Several subordinates who had been waiting in a sheltered spot near the building stepped out. One black?clad guard noticed the distant look in Agatha’s eyes and grew worried at once: “Are you all right, Gatekeeper? In that house…”

Agatha raised her hand and cut the subordinate off. She glanced back once, then lifted her Gatekeeper’s cane and slowly walked toward the steam car not far away, speaking as she went: “Do not disturb the residents of that house. Inform the Cathedral in this district and have the Guardians keep their distance from here—the Silent Cathedral will take over all contact with this place directly.”

“Yes, Gatekeeper,” the black?clad guard bowed his head at once to take the order, then could not help asking, “Do you… need to rest a bit?”

Agatha’s steps paused for a moment. She sighed: “If I could, I would go to the nearest Cathedral to seek mental counseling, or consult a well?known psychiatrist…”

The subordinate froze. “Ah?”

“Never mind, I don’t need rest,” Agatha waved her hand. “Let’s go back to the Grand Cathedral. We have to start the search under the city as soon as possible.”

…

“The Church people have left,” Morris stood by the window, watching the movements on the street outside. When he saw the gray?blue steam car drive out of the intersection, he turned and looked at Duncan. “I thought they would at least leave a few ‘eyes’ behind.”

“A Gatekeeper’s position in the Death Church is equivalent to an Inquisitor in the Deep Sea Church. She has to keep her word. Since she said they would not disturb us, there will naturally be no tricks,” Vanna said from the side. “Besides, she knows those little tricks would be meaningless.”

Duncan lifted his eyelids and glanced at Vanna: “I thought you might talk with that Gatekeeper a bit more. You two are colleagues, after all.”

“…I really couldn’t think of anything worth talking about,” Vanna shook her head. “My status is a little awkward. Whether I speak as an Inquisitor of the Deep Sea Church or as a member of the Vanished, forming ties with Frostholm’s Church at a time like this would only bring trouble.”

Duncan grunted in reply and said nothing more. It was Nina at his side who suddenly broke the silence with curiosity: “That Gatekeeper sister seemed a bit excited before she left, as if she had some kind of plan… What search plan was she talking about? Uncle, do you have any idea?”

Vanna and Morris both looked at Duncan. After a short silence, he nodded slightly.

Although he had been confused at first, by now he had figured it out. Agatha’s reaction showed one thing: after fruitless searches in the main areas of the city?state, Frostholm’s Church had apparently turned its attention to the dark world underground.

The Second Waterway.

In the past, limited by high costs and the practical difficulty of the task, Frostholm’s authority had always let the Second Waterway left from the Queen’s era lie dormant in the depths beneath the city. At most they did some symbolic purification and sealing work in the upper sections connected to the waterway. But now… it seemed they could no longer afford to worry about costs.

Duncan raised his head and said to Vanna: “Go to Nemo’s tavern again this afternoon and warn him. The Church may soon launch operations targeting the Second Waterway. He and his ‘colleagues’ should be careful.”

The Second Waterway was enormous, and in truth Nemo and his “peers” only controlled a small part of the entire sewer system. That part was very well hidden and had been intentionally concealed and sealed off. In theory,

the authority and the Church would never notice it. But no one knew how determined the Church would be this time, so it was better to warn him.

“Also, the matter of Dagger Island is worrying,” Duncan added after a brief thought. “The way that island disappeared is clearly abnormal. I’m afraid something else may happen later. Morris, watch all kinds of news in the city over the next few days, especially in the districts near the eastern Harbor. See if any unusual rumors come up.”

Morris nodded. “Understood.”

“We also need to remind Tyrian later, and have him watch for changes in that stretch of sea…”

Duncan rubbed his chin, muttering in thought as he wondered if he was missing anything. Just then he saw Shirley sidle over from the side.

She moved on tiptoe, looking very sneaky.

“What is it?” Duncan asked casually when he saw her.

“It’s not me, it’s Dog,” Shirley waved her hands quickly, then lifted her arm. A pitch?black chain emerged from the air, and Dog, who had hurriedly hidden himself earlier when the Gatekeeper arrived, appeared in front of Duncan. “Dog says he has something to report to you…”

“Something?” Duncan frowned, looking at the cowering Deep Sea hound. “What is it?”

Dog shook his ugly big head, then carefully glanced toward the door before speaking: “I don’t know if I’m sensing wrong. That ‘Gatekeeper’ called Agatha just now… I kept feeling she had a familiar aura about her…”

The room went quiet at once. Duncan’s gaze turned serious. “A familiar aura? What do you mean? Deep Sea Demons?”

“No, not Deep Sea Demons,” Dog shook his head at once. “I can’t really explain it. You know my memories from before I got a ‘heart’ are a bit blurry. But that aura… it reminded me a little of the Deep Sea Lord. Mm, of the feeling I had when I was near the Deep Sea Lord.”

As soon as Dog said this, everyone looked at each other. Duncan’s expression grew stern at once: “Why didn’t you say so earlier?”

“I didn’t dare show myself just now!” Dog hunched his neck. “She’s a Gatekeeper, after all. Of course she wouldn’t be your match, but Frostholm is hunting Annihilators and Deep Sea Demons across the whole city right now. I was afraid that if I showed up, I wouldn’t be able to explain myself and would end up delaying your work…”

Dog’s explanation did make some sense, and Duncan did not press him. Even so, what he reported clearly took everyone by surprise.

Frostholm’s Gatekeeper, Agatha… how could she carry the aura of the Deep Sea Lord?!

“Could it be… that Gatekeeper has already fallen? Or already been corrupted?” Morris said, his face grave. “But she behaved completely normally. There was nothing wrong with her words and actions…”

“Maybe she doesn’t even know?” Shirley said carefully from the side. “Isn’t cognitive corruption the hardest to notice? Especially for the person it’s happening to.”

Duncan said nothing, only looked up at Vanna.

“She didn’t seem like someone who has already fallen or been corrupted, and she was clearly not a ‘replica’,” Vanna said slowly, brows tightly knit as she carefully recalled every detail about Agatha just now. “I didn’t feel any abnormal aura on her at all. Dog, are you sure you weren’t mistaken?”

“I already said I’m not sure I sensed it right,” Dog replied, sounding especially guilty. “It was only a very, very faint aura that made me think of the Deep Sea, that’s all… Maybe it didn’t even come from her herself. Right, didn’t she say they’d caught some Annihilators recently? Even if none of them were important figures, if she’s been dealing with them every day lately, it’s normal for her to pick up a little aura from the Deep Sea on her, isn’t it…”

Duncan still frowned.

Dog’s explanation sounded somewhat reasonable, but he could not shake the feeling that things were not that simple. Would a professional servant of the Goddess, the city?state’s Gatekeeper, forget to perform self?purification after interrogating cultists? Would she really walk around outside carrying the cultists’ aura on her?

Vanna took a step forward: “Should we call that Gatekeeper back and ask about it? Or should we go to her?”

“Neither. If she truly is at risk of falling or has formed a link with the power of the Deep Sea, any direct contact could alert her,” Duncan shook his head, then looked toward the direction where Agatha had left. “I will keep a covert eye on this matter. You must not approach her.”

Covert eye?

Vanna paused for a moment. She was about to ask what exactly Duncan meant by “covert eye” when she suddenly seemed to remember something. Certain memories surfaced in her mind, and she immediately understood.

“You… already left a mark on her?”

“She has already seen me.”

Duncan nodded slightly. In his other field of vision, some distance away from here, a small green flame flickered gently.

It was exactly in the direction where Agatha had gone.

Chapter 372: Deeply Off Course

On the way back to the Cathedral, Agatha was weighed down with worries.

Confirming that the “Second Waterway” was the right direction for exploration counted as good news for her. But the identity of that mysterious being was still hidden in fog, and that left her unable to calm down no matter what. Of course, it was now certain that this being’s attitude toward the city-state of Frostholm was friendly. Yet as the leader of the Guardians of this city, she had to think long-term.

Any upper supernatural’s gaze upon the mortal world was never without a reason. In a sense, their gaze itself was a disturbance that had real effects. How much longer would that mysterious “visitor” keep his gaze on this place? What long-term impact would his stay have on Frostholm? Would the people living in the city-state change under that influence? Did that being know about this influence? Or… did He simply not care?

A small steam core let out a low, powerful growl as the gear-driven vehicle rolled along the old streets of the city-state. The scenery on both sides of the road slid back toward the edges of her vision. The car passed yet another intersection, and its speed slowed a little.

Her subordinate’s voice came from the front driver’s seat: “Lord, are we going straight back to the Cathedral?”

Agatha lifted her head and looked through the window toward the Cathedral.

The Silent Cathedral, as always, quietly looked down over the entire city-state.

At the center of Frostholm stood a mountain, roughly cone-shaped, rising high above the city's heart. Beneath it lay the Boiling Gold mines that brought endless wealth to the city. The Silent Cathedral and City Hall stood together on the mountaintop. The two large buildings shared the highest point in the city-state. No matter where you stood in the city, you could see them.

At least one of them.

The Cathedral was towering and solemn, looking almost holy against the sky. Across from it, City Hall was also an impressive structure. Half a century ago, in the Queen's era, it had actually been a palace. Official records called it the "Winter Court", but more people simply called it the Queen's Palace.

In that age, which people now treated as taboo, the Winter Court and the Silent Cathedral had looked down on the city like a pair of twins. Old stories full of strange charm painted them as two symbolic powers of protection. The Church guarded the city's veil of night, and the royal family guarded its daylight. The two sides supported and upheld each other.

In truth, things were not so different now. The worldly power represented by City Hall still guarded this city—only the Queen's era had ended.

Agatha drifted off a little. Without realizing it, she stared at that mountain, the mountain she had already seen countless times, and at the two buildings that sat on it like a crown. To her, they looked like two giant beasts standing on the peak, while the houses and factories scattered along the slopes were like blood spilling from those beasts, winding down the mountain's sides.

Her eyes started to sting.

“Gatekeeper, are we going back to the Cathedral?”

Her subordinate’s voice came again from the front seat. Agatha snapped out of her daze and blinked. It felt as if a faint buzzing still lingered in her ears, but a second later that lingering buzz vanished, together with the brief memory from just now.

“No, go to the sewage treatment plant first,” Agatha shook her head and said. “That ‘replica’ that vanished in the washroom worries me too much. I have to see it with my own eyes.”

“Yes.”

The steam core roared to life again. The car drew a neat arc at the intersection and turned onto the road leading to the sewage treatment plant.

…

The sky was covered by thick clouds. Dim daylight moved weakly within them, murky and unclear. In the distance stretched endless seawater, with a thin mist drifting over the waves.

Lawrence stood at the bow of the White Oak, frowning as he gazed at the distant view—the same view that had not changed for a very long time.

He turned and looked the other way. That side of the sea was also nothing but endless water. There were no other ships in sight, and not even a hint of any city-state.

Cold wind swept across the deck, tugging at his coat and the white hair at his temples. Lawrence’s frown had not eased for a long time.

“How long have we been away from Frostholm?” he suddenly asked, turning to the first mate beside him.

“A day and a night, Captain,” the first mate answered at once. “We have been at full speed the whole time.”

“Something is wrong… Why do I keep feeling that we’re going in circles…” Lawrence’s face grew solemn as he looked up at the murky light above. Then he seemed to recall something and asked: “Can the wireless telegraph pick up signals from any nearby city-state or the Harbor?”

“Yes,” the first mate nodded, his face also serious now. “But Frostholm is the only one.”

Lawrence drew a slow breath: “What does it say?”

“A welcome message,” the first mate said slowly. “‘The Harbor is open, welcome to Frostholm.’ We keep receiving that same message again and again.”

Lawrence’s brow furrowed even tighter. He said nothing. After a brief silence, the first mate muttered: “It’s like… we’re still circling Frostholm.”

“It’s obvious we’re trapped in this stretch of sea,” Lawrence said in a low voice. “How is the mood on board?”

“Everyone has realized something is wrong, but they’re all staying calm,” the first mate said. He glanced back toward the deck, where sailors were busy at their posts. “They’re good people—we’ve seen ‘strange things’ on the Boundless Sea before. They all believe you can get us out of this, so no one is bothering you.”

Lawrence did not answer. He only lifted his head and looked again at the murky sky.

The first mate noticed this strange action and could not help asking: “What are you looking at?”

“I…” Lawrence rubbed his temples. For some reason he felt a bit dazed, as if he had forgotten something very important. “I’m thinking about our course.”

“Our course?”

“Yes, our course.” Lawrence squeezed his eyes shut and opened them again, trying to recall what he had forgotten while he spoke almost to himself. “Don’t you think… we’ve forgotten something? Our current course… shouldn’t we be checking it somehow?”

The first mate froze for a second, then spoke without thinking: “Check the course? You mean the Stargazing Room? The navigator…”

“Wait, no, not the Stargazing Room,” Lawrence cut him off, as if slowly waking from a long dream. “The Stargazing Room is for checking the route in special cases. It carries corruption and can’t be used too often. There should be an easier, more common, safer method—something you can use in the daytime to confirm the ship’s direction. There should be such a method…”

His words came faster and faster. Then something seemed to occur to him, and he suddenly turned and ran toward the captain’s cabin.

The first mate, completely confused, instinctively followed. He went with Lawrence back to the captain’s cabin and then watched as the older man started rummaging through the room. At last he could not help asking: “What are you looking for?”

“Some kind of instrument. Used in the daytime. To check our course…” Lawrence dug through his things as he spoke quickly. A strong impression slowly resurfaced in his mind. He felt he was about to remember it, about to know what he was looking for… Suddenly his eyes fell on the desk not far away.

A small instrument sat there. It was made of a short telescope tube and several strange marked rulers.

Lawrence slowly walked over and picked up the little device, puzzled, trying hard to recall what it was for.

A moment later, holding the instrument in thought, he left the cabin and stepped out onto the deck. Under the first mate's baffled gaze, he raised the instrument to his eye and aimed it at the sky.

"Captain, what are you doing?" the first mate asked, curious.

Lawrence slowly lowered the device.

A faint green light seemed to flicker deep in his eyes, but neither he nor the first mate standing opposite noticed it.

The old captain's face showed only confusion and shock. He locked eyes with the first mate for a few seconds before speaking in a hoarse voice, slowly: "Do you remember… that in the sky there was something that shone with light and heat? It moved above us on time and on schedule, and ships could use it to check their course during the day…"

The first mate's eyes slowly widened, as if some memory or impression was also waking up inside his mind.

Lawrence turned his head again, staring at the chaotic clouds and the hazy, dim light behind them. Its source could not be seen. The daylight seemed to spread out evenly, with no sign of a clear, intense glowing orb anywhere in the clouds.

He drew back his gaze and stared straight at his first mate: "Where did the Sun go?"

The first mate could only repeat the captain's words in a daze: "…Where did the Sun go?"

"This isn't just getting lost, not a navigation lock, not looping Visions…" Lawrence murmured. "The White Oak has entered an Anomaly space as a

whole…”

The first mate slowly lifted his head and looked at the vast sea beyond the rail, his eyes filled with confusion and fear.

But suddenly he seemed to notice something.

A stretch of land had appeared on the sea.

It was a small island.

Chapter 373: “Go to Frostholm”

It was an island with a twisting shoreline and rocky cliffs. A layer of fog covered it, so they could not see what lay on it clearly. They could only vaguely make out the rising and falling terrain, and strange silhouettes hidden in the mist that looked like jagged rocks or collapsed buildings.

It had appeared very suddenly, as if it had popped into existence out of nowhere near the White Oak.

“What is that?” The first mate stared in shock at the island’s outline on the distant sea. The tense fear that had surged up when the idea of the Sun suddenly returned to him had not yet faded, and now another island had suddenly appeared. Even this old seafarer, who had dealt with the Boundless Sea for many years, had a slight tremor in his voice. “An island… Is there such an island near Frostholm? Is there one like that on our planned route?”

“There is no planned route anymore. The White Oak is sailing in a sea of Visions—we have left the Mortal Realm behind. Whatever we see is ‘normal’ now,” Lawrence’s steady voice came, carrying a strange power that calmed the heart. Though just a moment ago he had been shocked by the Sun’s disappearance, the old captain now seemed completely composed. “As for islands… There is a ‘Dagger Island’ near Frostholm, but I’m not sure this is it… It doesn’t quite match the identification chart.”

“What should we do?” The first mate turned to him. “Sail closer, or stay away?”

Lawrence fell silent, weighing things quickly in his mind.

The island had appeared all of a sudden, right after he and the first mate suddenly became aware of the idea of the Sun again. Was its appearance linked to that cognitive correction?

The island was wrapped in fog. Was that fog real, or was it an illusion born of warped perception?

Was the island fixed in place? Could the White Oak really get away from it? If its appearance was some kind of deliberate act, then no matter how the White Oak sailed, it might keep showing up ahead of the ship.

But no matter what, they should not rush toward it if they wanted to be cautious.

“Go around it,” Lawrence said in a deep voice. “Pass it on the left, full speed away.”

“Yes, Captain!”

The first mate hurried to the bridge. Moments later, a loud whistle echoed over the White Oak. Lawrence felt the ship under his feet begin to turn, and deep inside the hull the steam engine roared with surging power.

Many sailors had already noticed the island that had suddenly appeared. Some moved to the rail, staring nervously at the mist-shrouded land in the distance. Under the eyes of them all, the island slowly fell behind the White Oak and drifted farther away.

Lawrence let out a breath and turned to walk toward the bridge as well.

His steps suddenly stopped.

A figure had appeared in his field of view—a woman in a captain’s uniform, with slightly wavy long hair falling down her back. She stood with her arms crossed, a faint smile on her face.

“Do you remember what I told you?” the figure asked, her tone full of helplessness. “You really should retire. Don’t wait to regret it only after I show up on your ship… Lawrence, you’re already old.”

“Martha…” Lawrence blurted out the name. Then he quickly reached into his pocket, wanting to take out that vial of potion.

At the same time, shock filled his mind. Why so fast? Why had the potion’s effect faded so soon? It had been only a day since Martha last appeared… Had the potion’s duration become this short already?

His hand was shaking. His arm was shaking. He finally touched the vial, but just as he was about to open it, a hand suddenly rested on his arm.

At some point Martha had come to his side. She reached out, pressing down on the old captain’s arm, worry on her face.

“The medicine doesn’t work anymore. You know that, deep down,” Martha said softly. “If you drink it now, I’ll go away for a little while, then show up again. If you drink a whole bottle, I’ll be gone longer, but I’ll still come back… Lawrence, the medicine doesn’t work anymore.”

“I… I don’t understand…” Lawrence blinked in hesitation. He looked at the dearest face from his memories, but only felt a cold air spreading through his heart. “I know my condition. That psychiatrist is a skilled expert, so why…”

“Your mind is being affected, Lawrence. Haven’t you felt it? This sea is affecting you,” Martha said gently. It might have been Martha’s voice, or it might have been Lawrence’s own subconscious speaking. Clearly, somewhere deep down, the experienced old captain had already sensed a bit of the truth. “As you stay here, your mind is decaying faster. Be careful, Lawrence. You’re already in the middle of the sea…”

“How do I leave this place?” Lawrence asked without thinking. Without noticing it, he had loosened his grip on the vial.

The small bottle fell to the deck with a clear shattering sound. The half bottle of potion inside spilled out and mixed with the puddles on the deck until they were one and the same.

Lawrence lowered his head, staring blankly at the broken vial.

Martha still held his arm as she spoke softly: “Go to Frostholm…”

Lawrence jolted, as if waking from a dream. He raised his head, but no one stood beside him anymore—only a bit of lingering warmth remained on his arm.

A rush of footsteps suddenly sounded not far away. Lawrence looked up and saw the first mate striding toward him.

“Captain, we’ve already ‘shaken off’ that island,” the first mate said quickly. Then he looked up and glanced around curiously, as if searching for someone. “Where’s the person who was with you just now? Is she also one of the sailors on board?”

“You saw wrong, I’ve been alone…” Lawrence started to say this out of habit, but halfway through he stopped and snapped his head up, staring at the first mate. “What did you say? The person who was with me just now?!”

“Yes. She was standing next to you just now, looked like a lady—but I didn’t see her clearly,” the first mate said, sounding a bit confused. “Did I really see wrong?”

Lawrence’s eyes went wide, so wide that the first mate was almost frightened. After several seconds, the captain finally burst out: “You could see her?!”

The first mate swallowed hard. He had no idea why his captain was reacting like this. “…I really did see her.”

No sooner had he said this than the experienced seafarer seemed to think of something. His face tightened. “Wait, was that an illusion just now? Have I been affected?”

“It was an illusion… but in theory it should have been one only I could see.” Lawrence’s face looked unusually bad. He waved a hand, telling the other man not to panic too much, but his own mind was a mess. “It shouldn’t be like this. It shouldn’t…”

The old captain lifted his head and glanced around in a daze, as if still hoping to catch sight of Martha.

In his mind, everything seemed to have been stirred together—reality, illusions, memories, delusions…

Here, the Mortal Realm and all that was unreal seemed to have no boundaries at all. Illusions that should have been visible only to him now appeared before others as well. False things were becoming real. And the real ones?

Was this stretch of sea real? Was the White Oak real?

What in the world was this place?

Lawrence’s thoughts were in complete disarray, but suddenly a sailor’s shout came from somewhere on the deck, cutting off his wild thinking.

Someone on watch had found something on the sea.

Lawrence and the first mate exchanged a glance, then hurried toward the side rail. Soon they saw what had made the sailors cry out—

An island had appeared off the White Oak’s forward side. It had a twisting shoreline and tall stone cliffs, and the island was wrapped in mist…

The island had appeared again.

“…That island can move…” The first mate swallowed nervously as his worst guess became reality before his eyes. “It has caught up to us…”

“Or it might be that we’ve been circling in place all along, and this sea is filled with ‘the Veil’ that can briefly blind our sight,” Lawrence said in a low voice, his eyes fixed on the island. “It’s even possible that ‘Frostholm’ is right beside us at this very moment…”

The first mate shot the captain a startled look. He had no idea why the old man had suddenly brought up “Frostholm”, but he quickly steadied himself and asked: “Captain, what do we do this time? Go around it again?”

Lawrence fell silent again, thinking fast.

Martha’s soft words beside his ear still echoed in his mind—

“Go to Frostholm.”

That island was certainly not the city-state of Frostholm, but it kept appearing near the White Oak. Perhaps that in itself was a kind of “guidance”.

Not long ago, he had led the White Oak in a hurried “escape” from the strangely unsettling city-state of Frostholm, only to become trapped in this unfamiliar sea. And now, “Martha” was guiding him again, telling him to “go to Frostholm”.

In front of him, an even more eerie island had appeared—twice now it had suddenly shown up beside the White Oak.

What choice was the right one?

“…We sail toward that island.”

Chapter 374: Envoy

Tyrian stood on the tall bridge of the Sea Mist, his gaze passing through the wide windows to the misty, endless sea in the distance.

That had once been the direction of Dagger Island—but now there was only a wide stretch of open water, and a few scout boats still searching for clues in vain.

Dagger Island had been gone for a long time now. Yet neither the people of Frostholm nor the Sea Mist fleet had found anything in these waters.

The Pirate Lord let out a quiet sigh, turned away from the bridge, and walked into his captain’s cabin. On the desk inside sat an antique oval ritual mirror, completely out of place beside the Sea Mist’s advanced fittings.

Tyrian stopped in front of the mirror and looked at his own reflection, hesitating a little.

Soon he pushed that hesitation aside. He reached into a drawer, took out a carved ritual candlestick used for ceremonies, and set it in front of the mirror.

“The Sea Mist calling the Vanished…” Tyrian muttered under his breath. At that moment, he felt like those seafarers who were bewitched by the manifestations on the Boundless Sea and driven into madness, offering up sacrificial victims in their final frenzy to call the horrors in the dark depths. And in truth, this was not so different. The power he was about to call really was the most terrifying force in all these waters.

It just happened that this power was his Father.

The candlestick lit itself. Bright flame danced above the candle, its light and shadow reflected in the mirror. Tyrian watched the tiny flame, a little nervous. It flickered a few times, then quickly turned a ghostly green. He knew his call had been received.

Flame swept across the oval surface of the mirror, while the center turned black as ink. Tyrian's own reflection vanished. A moment later, another figure appeared there: Duncan's true body, still aboard the Vanished.

Duncan was holding a piece of bread. He lifted his head, glanced this way through the mirror, and said: "I was just about to have lunch—have you eaten?"

"Uh… not yet." Tyrian froze for a second and answered, still not quite used to this. Ever since his Father had regained his humanity, he seemed to have changed in small, quiet ways. His greetings had become so different. The good part was that those greetings felt warm and friendly. But Tyrian had gone too many years without speaking so naturally with his Father. He still felt very awkward.

"You should eat lunch on time. It's good for your health," Duncan said casually. "So, what did you need from me?"

"We've already searched the entire sea around Dagger Island and found nothing," Tyrian steadied himself and turned back to business. "The people of Frostholm are still searching, but I think they will also come up empty."

"The Deep Sea swallowed that island. The real problem is below the surface. Searching from above is meaningless. And right now our biggest problem is that we don't have proper diving apparatus," Duncan said, shaking his head. "Also, the city is getting tense. The Church will soon

expand their search to the Second Waterway. Don’t worry, I’ve already sent warnings to your informants.”

Tyrian tensed up at once when he heard that the Church was going to search the Second Waterway, but he relaxed again at the second half of Duncan’s words. Then he frowned and asked: “They suspect the heretics’ nest in the city is hidden in the Second Waterway?”

“After all, they’ve already turned the rest of the city-state upside down,” Duncan lifted his eyelids. “Other than the Second Waterway, they have nowhere else to look.”

Tyrian frowned without speaking. Seeing this, Duncan asked: “What is it? Do you have some idea?”

“I don’t think they’ll find any clues in the Second Waterway,” Tyrian said slowly, shaking his head. “My informants don’t control the whole Second Waterway, but they know what it’s like down there and hold several key nodes. If a large number of Annihilators were hiding below and holding some great ritual there… I should have heard something.”

“Maybe they’re hiding very well. Or maybe the ritual they’re holding has already twisted the minds of every informant who noticed anything—either they didn’t notice, or if they did, they were corrupted. That would keep you from getting any reliable information.”

Tyrian nodded slowly. “That does make sense. You already confirmed that there is cognitive corruption inside the city-state.”

“I’ll keep an eye on the Second Waterway as well,” Duncan said from inside the mirror. “I’m very curious where those Annihilators are hiding. If I see your people getting into trouble along the way, I’ll try to help.”

“Thank you very much.” Tyrian bowed his head at once.

Just then, a sudden knock at the door cut off the conversation in the captain’s cabin.

“Someone is looking for you,” Duncan said from the mirror, having heard the noise. “If there’s nothing else, you should go take care of your own work.”

“Okay, Father.”

Duncan’s figure faded from the mirror. The flames along the edge of the fiery surface vanished, and the candlestick in front of the mirror slowly went back to normal.

Tyrian let out a long breath and felt the pressure in his chest ebb away. Then he frowned, stood up, and opened the door: “What is it?”

“A fast boat from Frostholm,” said an Undying sailor with a hole in his head, standing in the doorway and saluting as he spoke. “They’re coming up under flags and light signals saying ‘non-military action’ and ‘request for contact’. Looks like a group of… envoys.”

“Envoys?” Tyrian was startled for a moment, then his face showed keen interest. “Now that is interesting… looks like they really couldn’t sit still.”

“Open fire?” the sailor asked, looking at his captain with some expectation.

“Fire my ass—let them come,” Tyrian glared at him, then added: “Only three people are allowed aboard. If they can’t accept that, they can go back where they came from.”

On the mechanical cutter flying Frostholm’s city-state flag, a man in a neat formal coat and gold-rimmed glasses stood on the foredeck. He nervously took off his glasses to wipe them again and again, then lifted his head to look at the ironclad warship that was growing larger in his field of view.

The Sea Mist came closer and closer. Its raised prow loomed like a mountain floating on the frozen sea, and the sense of pressure grew stronger. All across the surrounding water, small chunks of ice drifted like living things. They swam in the sea, circled the cutter's hull with purpose, and kept ramming the planks near the waterline.

The constant crack of ice throwing itself against the hull set people's teeth on edge and drew their nerves tight.

The confidential secretary wiped his glasses again. In his mind rose the stories told in Frostholm, passing from mouth to mouth. They were all about the curse on the outer sea, the Pirate Lord in the fog, sailors frozen into ice sculptures in their sleep, and a Pirate Lord who ate one small child with every meal.

"We're close enough," the confidential secretary said. He put his gold-rimmed glasses back on, took a slow breath, and spoke to the accompanying officer beside him: "Stop here. If we go any closer, that warship will start shooting."

"Slowest speed, port rudder!" the officer turned and shouted orders to the signal sailor.

The cutter's speed dropped at once. It adjusted its heading a little, slowly turning until it lay parallel to the vast ironclad warship.

At the same time, the officer kept his eyes on the Sea Mist.

He saw flashes of light appear on the warship. Then a seaman stepped out by the rail and waved signal flags toward the mechanical cutter.

"They're sending a signal," the confidential secretary said quickly. "What does it mean?"

"The Sea Mist has accepted our request… thank the gods, this time it's a signal living people can read," the officer let out a long breath. Then he saw

a small boat being lowered from the warship's side. "And they're putting a boat in the water to pick us up."

"God of Death bless us… I thought they would just start firing," the confidential secretary said, also clearly relieved. As the first "envoy" sent to negotiate with the Sea Mist fleet, he had already prepared himself to die for the city-state before coming here. Even so, he still felt the sharp joy of someone who had just escaped death.

The small boat from the Sea Mist soon reached Frostholm's cutter. Several Undying sailors in Old Era naval uniforms sat aboard it.

The Queen's emblem on their arms and their uniforms from a bygone age drew every eye. Even more striking than their clothes, though, was the fact that they were Undying.

Two of them had gaping holes in their heads. Another had a hole straight through his chest. Only one seemed to be without visible wounds—yet his swollen, bloated body looked like the corpse of someone who had been soaking in seawater for three days.

The Frostholm seamen on the cutter grew nervous at the sight of these Undying sailors. When they watched them step onto their ship, many showed complex and troubled looks.

The Undying did not seem to care how the living felt. They walked straight toward the person who looked like the highest-ranking officer on deck.

"Who is the envoy?"

"That would be me." The man in the short formal coat and gold-rimmed glasses stepped forward at once. He fought down his nervousness and forced himself not to stare at the Undying sailors' terrible wounds. Keeping his voice as calm as he could, he said: "My name is Eddie Ruhl. I represent the city-state of Frostholm in talks with the Sea Mist fleet."

“A clerk?” The swollen Undying sailor frowned and gave Eddie a slow once-over, his tone mocking. “I thought you would at least send some military men. Has Frostholm’s navy already run out of soldiers with enough courage?”

The officer beside Eddie stepped forward half a pace at once, but before he could speak, Eddie lifted his hand to stop him.

“I am the envoy,” the civil official with the gold-rimmed glasses said, looking at the Undying sailor. “Take me to see General Tyrian.”

Chapter 375: Reflection

Eddie boarded the small boat bound for the Sea Mist. The Undying sailors with their dreadful faces looked him up and down like they were studying a rare beast.

The confidential secretary felt uncomfortable all over, even a little chilled to the bone.

“I really didn’t expect you to insist on coming alone,” the swollen Undying sailor said, sounding almost admiring. “Our captain said he would let three people come aboard.”

“There’s no difference between three and one,” Eddie said, shaking his head. “If General Tyrian allowed me to bring an entire team, of course I would bring all my advisers and assistants. But he only allows three people… so it’s no different from going by myself.”

“You could bring two soldiers along to steady your nerves.” Another Undying sailor burst out laughing. The wind whistled in and out of his holed throat as he did.

“I don’t need help with my nerves. soldiers wouldn’t be any use,” Eddie said, very serious.

His answer made the Undying sailors lose interest. Someone muttered on the boat: “…posing official.”

A short while later, Tyrian met the envoy from the city-state—a man in formal dress with gold-rimmed glasses, hair combed so neatly it might have

just been done, a man in his thirties or forties who looked as if he had been drinking tea in an office only a moment before.

He was slick and well-groomed, and he had come alone.

The Pirate Lord, who had been ready for something very different, was surprised. He even felt a little awkward, with his strength having nowhere to go. He had thought the first person to board the Sea Mist would at least be from the military.

Soon, though, he guessed what Frostholm's authorities had in mind.

Relations between the Sea Mist fleet and the city-state were already tense. The two sides had faced each other over a powder keg for fifty years. In such a sensitive moment, sending a few more officers over to talk would do no good at all. Sending a clerk at least showed some goodwill.

This clerk, however, was clearly a little nervous.

On the deck of the Sea Mist, Tyrian looked the "city-state diplomat" up and down. He could easily see the forced calm in the man's eyes and hear the uneven rhythm of his breathing. The man's poise would have been enough to fool ordinary people, but it could not fool a captain who commanded a legion of Undying.

Tyrian could even hear every beat of the diplomat's heart.

Eddie was also studying the Pirate Lord in front of him—the man who had once defended the city-state, and who had now become the source of almost every horror story in Frostholm.

Tall, strong, silent, and stern, with a single eye that held both judgment and cold disdain, every one of Tyrian's glances felt like a verdict.

In front of this Pirate Lord, even breathing seemed hard work.

“General Tyrian,” Eddie said. He took two deep breaths, straightened his back, and met the Pirate Lord’s gaze. “On behalf of the city-state of Frostholm, I offer you our greetings. I’m very glad to stand on this legendary warship.”

“Half a century,” Tyrian said. He looked calmly at the man who was a head shorter than he was. “It took Frostholm half a century to find the courage to speak to me?”

Eddie ignored the provocation in his words and went on: “I came here under orders. The feud between Frostholm and the Sea Mist fleet is real, but that is not what we are here to discuss today. You know what kind of trouble the city-state is facing. We only want to know the purpose of the Sea Mist fleet’s arrival. Captain Tyrian, what do you want, and what do you intend to do?”

“‘General’… spare me that title. I don’t enjoy it,” Tyrian said. He gave Eddie a light glance and walked slowly toward the rail. “As for what I intend to do… isn’t it obvious? I’m blockading this city-state that is about to fall, to keep your mess from spreading and hurting my ‘trade partners’ on the Frost Sea.”

“Trade partners?”

“I think that’s a fair name. They pay the price, and the Sea Mist fleet protects their safety on the Frost Sea,” Tyrian turned his head. “Don’t you think that’s an excellent trade relationship?”

Eddie’s mouth twitched, but he quickly hid the change. He glanced at the Undying sailors around them, then walked slowly to Tyrian’s side and said: “You mean… you simply want to help Frostholm contain this crisis?”

“That’s a bit self-flattering, but if you want to see it that way, I won’t object,” Tyrian said lightly. “I don’t really need you to do anything, as long

as you don’t get in my way.”

Eddie fell silent for two seconds, then finally asked with care: “May I know why you are helping us at all?”

Tyrian rested both hands on the rail and did not turn his head. “Is that reason so important?”

“I need a reason. It will help my superiors and my colleagues feel a little easier.”

“Ah, Mr. Eddie, so what you need is a reason that can put people’s hearts at rest.” Tyrian laughed and turned back, locking eyes with Eddie. “Then I’ll tell you the reason—it’s simply my Father’s order.”

Eddie froze.

A moment later, horror crept visibly over his face.

“Looks like you understand,” Tyrian went on. “Yes, my Father’s orders. You can think of them as coming from Subspace. He told me to surround your pitiful little city-state with troops. So go back and tell your superiors that the Sea Mist fleet is carrying out the will of Subspace,” Tyrian said, his tone quite cheerful. “Then they can all sleep like babies.”

The joy on the Pirate Lord’s face was plain. Eddie finally reacted—or thought he did. He let out a long breath and wiped the sweat from his brow. “That joke is not funny at all, Captain Tyrian… I understand. Since you don’t wish to explain further, I won’t ask.”

Tyrian stared at the “Frostholm ambassador” in front of him for a moment, then clicked his tongue.

These days, no one believed the truth.

Still, his mood was very good.

It was fun to watch this deadly serious Frostholm high official jump at every word in front of him.

“You may go, Mr. Eddie,” he said politely. “We haven’t prepared dinner for you aboard.”

Eddie clearly froze. “Ah? Wait, I still—”

“You still have many questions,” Tyrian said, still calm. “About the Sea Mist fleet’s next plans. About Dagger Island. About the Queen and the Abyssal Trench Project in those days. But sadly, I don’t have much to say to Frostholm. You’ve already achieved your goal and finished your mission. Go back and report to your superiors. If anything else comes up later, you can contact us by wireless telegraph. There’s no need to send people anymore. We can hear you on any open frequency.”

Eddie blinked, then quickly understood, and a trace of joy crossed his face. “Ah, all right, Captain Tyrian. Thank you very much for your understanding…”

He stopped there, as if something had just come to mind, then hurried to add: “Ah, wait, one more question—the last question!”

Tyrian raised an eyebrow. “Oh?”

“It’s about… that mysterious light signal you flashed to our scout boat before,” Eddie said, his face a little awkward as he chose his words. “We spent a long time trying to decode it after we went back…”

Tyrian watched him quietly, staring at the envoy until Eddie’s expression grew more and more strained under his gaze. Then Tyrian suddenly smiled.

“The sailors were careless with maintenance. The signal lamp was broken, that’s all.”

Eddie: “…?”

Tyrian finally burst into happy laughter.

Eddie’s face went through a series of changes. His hand brushed over the buttons of his coat. But in the end, he also began to laugh, and soon he was laughing along with Tyrian.

Then Tyrian stopped laughing all at once.

He reached out and slapped the “Frostholm ambassador” on the shoulder.

“They sent a very good man, Mr. Eddie. I almost want to invite you to stay aboard for dinner.”

“But I have to get back to my ship in time,” Eddie said, also stopping his laughter and slowly shaking his head. “Too many people are on edge. We can’t keep pouring all our energy into watching and guessing about each other.”

Tyrian said nothing. He only nodded gently, then held out his hand to the side in a gesture of farewell.

Eddie nodded back, straightened his coat and tie, and started toward the ladder on the other side of the deck.

Just then, something seemed to catch at the edge of his vision, and his footsteps stopped.

The Frostholm envoy walked to the rail in surprise and looked down at the sea. “…Captain Tyrian, what is that?”

“Hm?” Tyrian frowned and followed the line of Eddie’s pointing finger.

He saw it. It was a shadow.

Beneath the surface, at a depth he could not judge, a hazy shadow was crossing the wide space between the Sea Mist and several escort ships, moving quickly away.

The shadow was faint and translucent, like the reflection of a ship cast into the water, yet no structure of the vessel could be seen. Tyrian stared at it for a long time. In the end he could only think that it looked like… the bottom of a ship.

It was as if an upside-down ship were sailing under the surface.

Tyrian lifted his head and looked toward the direction where the shadow was sailing.

That was the direction where Dagger Island had once been.

Chapter 376: Entrenched

The sound of machinery echoed through the plant. Water thundered through the giant pipes, and a sharp, chemical stench hung in the air, strong enough to make one's stomach churn.

Agatha stood by the safety railing and leaned forward to look down into the buffer pool. Filthy liquid churned and rolled in the huge reservoir. Bubbles rose from the surface now and then, along with strange, shifting colors of light, disgusting like the stomach acid of some great beast.

A manager in a light brown coat, his thinning hair plastered to his scalp, stood behind the young Gatekeeper. His face looked tense, and one hand tugged nervously at the button on his chest.

"The drainage from the north side of Oak Street and the area around Cemetery No. 4 all converges here," the manager said. He watched the Gatekeeper's expression as he reported, speaking very carefully. "After we received the order, we cut off all nearby pipe connections at once and checked the alarm devices on every buffer pool. We did not find any sign of blasphemous corruption…"

Agatha listened in silence for a while, then suddenly asked: "How is the sewage usually treated?"

"How is it treated?" The manager froze for a second, then hurried to answer. "First we use high-pressure steam to carry out purification on any possible corruption—you know how it is. The sewage has been in contact with humans and then flows through dark pipes. It is bound to become a

carrier for certain things. After the steam purification comes settling and filtration. What you see now is the settling tank. Then we perform a second steam purification. After that purification, part of the water is sent back into the factories for recycling, and the rest… is discharged into the sea."

Agatha gave a small nod and asked again: "Roughly how long does it take for sewage discharged from the north side of Oak Street to reach this place?"

"That depends on the exact route, but usually no more than two hours," the manager answered.

"How long does the sewage stay here?"

"The water in the settling tanks is replaced every seventy-two hours." The manager raised his hand. Under the Gatekeeper's steady questions, he grew more and more nervous. He wiped the sweat from his forehead, but still answered with precision. "The purification and inspection procedures are strictly regulated. They never run shorter than that."

Agatha nodded slightly and quickly worked through the timing in her mind. She compared the hour of the "replica incident" in that townhouse with the sewage treatment schedule. Then she said, half to herself: "So if that thing really escaped through the drainage system, it should still be here…"

"Gatekeeper," the administrator blurted, wiping his shining forehead again. At last he could not hold back his curiosity. "What exactly… happened? Is there corruption spreading through the waste system?"

"…We cannot rule that out," Agatha replied. She glanced at the administrator, then turned her gaze toward the nearby black-clad Guardians who were collecting samples and testing the equipment. "But according to everything we have checked so far, everything here is normal."

“Yes,” the manager said, forcing a weak smile. “Every stage here has an alarm device, built to detect possible blasphemous corruption. The treatment center also has three resident priests. They test water samples every day…”

“Resident priests?” Agatha seemed to think of something and turned her head. “How many resident priests did you say are here?”

“Th… three,” the manager stammered at once, perhaps scared by the sudden edge in Agatha’s tone. “Is… is there a problem?”

“You can only have two priests here,” Agatha said coldly. “The number of resident priests in each municipal facility is strictly regulated. Where did the third one come from?”

The manager’s expression went blank. A new sheen of sweat appeared on his forehead, and fear rose in his eyes.

Seeing this, Agatha lifted her Gatekeeper’s cane and rested it on his shoulder. She crushed the “fear” in his mind by force. Her face grew stern as she said: “Listen. From this point on, you must remain calm. Go bring all the resident priests here. Tell them the Gatekeeper needs more information. Do not show any other emotion. Do you understand?”

The administrator’s mood settled quickly, though he still looked a little nervous. He nodded in a rush. “Yes, I… I understand… I’ll go right away.”

Agatha nodded and withdrew the Gatekeeper’s cane. As he was about to leave, something else occurred to her, and she spoke up at once: “Wait. Not just the resident priests—bring everyone.”

The manager turned back, stunned. “Everyone?”

“Everyone,” Agatha repeated in a low voice. Then, still uneasy, she asked, “Since yesterday, has anyone left this treatment center?”

“No!” the manager answered at once. “When we got the order, it was fifteen minutes before shift change. Everyone working here stayed.”

“Good. Bring them all here. Tell them it is a necessary inspection. Keep your manner relaxed. Do not arouse suspicion. Go.”

The balding administrator turned and hurried away, trying to steady his emotions as he went. Agatha stood motionless by the buffer pool. Only when she saw him vanish through a nearby door did she raise her hand and signal to the Guardians who had already noticed the commotion.

The black-clad Guardians nearby moved at once. On the open ground around the buffer pool they laid out hidden runes. At crossroads and between pipes they sprinkled essential oils and powdered incense, then took up their positions, still looking as if they were merely inspecting the equipment.

While the Guardians worked, Agatha lifted the Gatekeeper’s cane and slowly traced a triangle on the floor around herself, each side about two meters long. Then she stood at the center of the triangle, resting both hands on the cane, and waited calmly.

It was not long before footsteps sounded from the main door. The administrator returned to the hall with a large crowd behind him.

Among them walked three clergy in the Death Church’s guildmaster robes, each wearing a Holy Emblem.

A dozen treatment center workers, led by the administrator, came up to Agatha and formed a loose line. Nervous, they greeted the Gatekeeper. The three resident priests stepped out from the side of the group and saluted her according to the Death Church’s internal etiquette.

Agatha ordered the three priests to spread out. Then her gaze slowly swept over every face.

She felt something wrong.

She saw no suspicious expression or movement. Her senses picked up no unusual aura. Yet Bartok's blessing had already told her that something was off—hidden in these people's breathing, hidden in their heartbeats, hidden even in the Shadows they cast upon the floor.

Agatha blinked and checked again. Everything she saw still looked normal. That only made her more certain.

There was indeed cognitive interference here—and even with a Gatekeeper present in person, that cognitive interference still held.

Was it simply because they had great courage? Or because they did not understand a Gatekeeper's power? Or… was this cognitive interference not under anyone's control at all?

Agatha slowly turned her head, fixing her eyes on the three priests.

She could leave the dozen workers aside for the moment. Among these three priests, at least one was false—but which one?

"Recite Bartok's name," Agatha said slowly. "Let the Death Sovereign's gaze fall upon us and let us tell illusion from truth in this world of dust."

"In the name of the Death Sovereign Bartok," one priest began at once, "may His gaze fall upon us…"

Then the second and the third priest opened their mouths in turn.

"In the name of the Death Sovereign Bartok…"

Three voices sounded one after another, like echoes.

Agatha frowned.

They could speak the god's name. That meant none of them was a mud-born replica, and none was a cultist loyal to a heretical faith. In such a case,

the violent clash of belief would have torn their minds apart.

But how could that be? Were all three priests genuine?

Thoughts flashed through Agatha's mind, but her face stayed calm. She nodded to the three. "Next, I need to perform some necessary tests. Please understand."

As she spoke, she reached for her left eye. At once, a living eyeball popped from her socket and landed neatly in her hand.

Agatha raised the eyeball and "looked" at the three priests before her.

The first priest appeared in her sight. He was a thin, elderly man in a linen robe. Black, ink-dark chains extended from beneath his ribs. At the end of the chains, a hound of the Abyssal Deep lifted its head. Blasphemous, filthy power was gathering and taking shape in its jaws.

Heretic.

He dared to stand here in plain sight.

Agatha's face changed slightly, but she had prepared for this. As the Abyssal Hound opened its huge mouth, she slipped aside. Her right hand lifted the Gatekeeper's cane, and pale flames burst into life at its tip.

But before she could burn the heretic, another low, obscure spell-chant suddenly rose beside her.

The eyeball in Agatha's left hand snapped around. In the next second she saw a young man with straw-yellow hair and a high nose raising both hands toward her. Behind him floated a grey-black Smokewisp Jellyfish, as if formed from condensed mist.

That was the second "priest."

A wave of dizziness swept over Agatha. As she tried to steady herself, she heard a third spell being chanted.

At the edge of her vision, a pale woman lifted her hand. A cat formed of bones and mist crouched at her side.

That was the third priest.

All the priests were false.

Roars and the sounds of combat rose from all sides.

The moment the three cultists of annihilation, disguised as Death Church priests, made their move, the Guardians around them reacted and tried to rush to Agatha's aid. But they found their own enemies waiting.

The dozen "workers" the administrator had brought and the nearby black-clad Guardians clashed in a sudden frenzy.

Out of the corner of her eye, Agatha saw those "workers" crack open when they were struck. Thick, muddy filth oozed out of their splitting bodies.

Only the balding administrator broke away and ran toward a nearby pipe, screaming in helpless terror.

The entire sewage treatment center… had only one human.

Chapter 377: Gatekeeper’s Battle

It all happened in an instant.

Three cultists of annihilation, disguised as Death Church priests, launched their surprise attack. Black-clad Guardians rushed in from all sides to help. The dozen staff from the sewage treatment center and the Guardians fell upon each other. All of this unfolded almost at the same time.

A shocking truth revealed itself: this entire treatment center had long since been fully corrupted and replaced.

No wonder there had been no sign of corruption in the settling tanks or any of the pipes. No wonder the elements that escaped through the sewers seemed to have “evaporated.” It already had a lair—right here, beneath the very noses of the city-state’s authority and the Church.

Yet countless mysteries still remained. How could cultists of annihilation, followers of the Abyssal Lord, call upon the name of the God of Death? How had the “replicas” disguised as plant workers slipped past her senses? Where had the real staff gone?

But the Mortal Realm did not give Agatha much time to think or deduce.

The Abyssal Hound’s dark breath, corrosive and full of force, roared toward her. The foul mass of energy passed so close that it nearly brushed her hair, then smashed into a pillar beside the settling tank and blew straight through it. The Smokewisp Jellyfish unleashed spiritual corruption that hammered at her mind. Her movements slowed. Her thoughts dulled. At the same time, the pale woman with the cat-shaped demon raised her hand from afar.

Countless crossing blood-lines appeared around Agatha. One edge of her coat brushed against those red lines, and the cloth at the point of contact instantly crumbled to dust.

This was a carefully prepared trap. No wonder those heretics had meekly gathered here to accept “inspection”—they meant to kill the Church’s Gatekeeper.

“Foolish.”

Agatha spoke lightly and tapped the Gatekeeper’s cane against the floor.

The soft touch of the cane-tip on the ground erupted like a clap of thunder. Waves of phantom ripples spread out from the end of the Gatekeeper’s cane in every direction. In an instant, everything around her fell still.

Darkness swallowed the space around the settling tank. Everything in sight turned grey and black. Those Guardians and “replicas” locked in combat froze where they stood. Only a thin, pale light slanted in from the far-off doors and windows, and from cracks that had appeared in the high roof. It made everything within sight hazy and indistinct.

In the Spirit Realm, Agatha held her eyeball in her left hand and “looked” toward the three cultists of annihilation, who were also frozen in place.

Beside them, the demons bound by symbiotic pacts with the Abyssal Deep burned with black flames. In this world of black, white, and grey, their fire burned in eerie stillness while their smoke rose as slowly as a scene in slow motion.

Agatha lifted the Gatekeeper’s cane and gave a light sweep through the air.

The dim, grey space jolted. At once, all the black-clad Guardians who had been fighting vanished from the Spirit Realm. Agatha raised her left hand, and within the range of the eyeball’s gaze there remained only the three

cultists of annihilation and the dozen twisted replicas formed of “elements” behind them.

“Feast,” Agatha said softly.

The beings of the Spirit Realm stirred. The Shadows lurking in the cracks of the world had received the Gatekeeper’s invitation and permission. In a heartbeat, countless shadows surfaced on every “surface” around the settling tank—on the floor, on the walls, along the pipes, even on the high roof.

They were like cheering crowds, like herds of beasts packed together. Massed Shadows surged along every surface, flowing toward the enemies in Agatha’s sight.

Every surface within sight crawled with moving Shadows, a sight to make the scalp prickle. But Agatha only watched it all in silence. Her right eye was open and calm, holding no emotion. Her left eye was tightly shut. In her left palm, the eyeball kept turning, never losing track of even the smallest stir around her.

The first to be surrounded were the replicas. The Shadows surged over them like an incoming tide. In a blink, they had spread across the replicas’ bodies and swallowed them whole, dissolving them in utter silence.

In the next moment, the Shadows rushed toward the three cultists of annihilation and the demons bound to them through symbiotic pacts.

The Abyssal demons sensed danger.

A strange cracking sound came from within their bodies and along their chains. The flames on all the Abyssal demons began to shudder violently. The edges of the cultists’ bodies rippled with the same strange vibration and blur. Inside this domain where all things were frozen, they struggled and “came alive.”

The young man bound to the Smokewisp Jellyfish was the first to break free. He tore himself out of the Spirit Realm's grip and, by instinct, raised his head to look toward Agatha.

Almost at the same time, the thin old man bound to the Abyssal Hound also broke loose. Seeing what his companion was doing, he shouted a warning:

"Don't meet the Gatekeeper's eyes!"

But his warning came too late. The young cultist had already turned his gaze toward the triangle where Agatha stood.

Agatha raised her left hand higher. She held up her eyeball as though offering it to the young cultist.

The heretic's eyes flew wide. His gaze locked onto the eyeball in Agatha's palm, his whole being caught by it. He stared, stunned, almost intoxicated. A quiet, peaceful smile slowly spread across his face.

As if in that moment, he had grasped the true meaning of life and death, and in that truth had found the whole purpose and answer of his existence.

"Ah, how beautiful…"

He spoke in a soft voice, then smiled and slowly fell backward into the tide of Shadows.

He and his Abyssal demon were torn into pieces in an instant by the endless Shadows.

But as that heretic fell, a strange shriek rang out from nearby. A sharp gust of wind pressed in from Agatha's right. She had to turn her body slightly to avoid it. An invisible blade skimmed past her forehead. She turned her head toward the source of the attack.

The pale woman bound to the cat-shaped demon was screaming at her. Her mouth split open like a twisting, inhuman maw. Blasphemous spells were

crushed into short, piercing cries. A new blade of wind was already taking shape.

On the other side, the Abyssal Hound had also prepared its next breath.

Agatha seemed to ignore the hound and the thin old man behind her. She lifted the Gatekeeper's cane and pointed it at the pale woman, who had already begun to distort like a demon. At the same time, she raised her left hand again, holding up the eyeball.

The pale woman instinctively tried to avoid the gaze of the eyeball in Agatha's hand—only to be met, in the next second, by a dull gunshot.

The front of the Gatekeeper's cane spat a burst of blinding fire. A heavy silver bullet blasted apart the pale woman's already torn and twisted head.

In the next heartbeat, as the heretic's headless body fell and the Shadows swallowed it, a mass of fiercely corrosive Abyssal Deep breath slammed into Agatha's back and exploded.

Black fire leapt up. Smoke and dust billowed. The hound's breath strike burst behind the Gatekeeper and quickly faded.

Agatha's black coat did not bear a single mark.

She slowly turned and looked at the last remaining cultist—the thin old man.

He stared at her, eyes wide with shock and terror.

"I thought that if you dared to set this trap, it must have been after careful study and planning," Agatha said, calmly fixing the final enemy with her gaze. "But judging by your expression, that is not the case. So… were you three merely expendable pawns?"

The last cultist's fear grew even stronger, and beneath it there was a hint of helpless confusion.

Agatha noticed the change in his eyes.

“Are you looking for this?” the young Gatekeeper said quietly.

The next second, she opened her mouth wide.

A foul mass of viciously corrosive Abyssal Deep breath formed at once in front of her. It shot forward with the same force and along the same path as before, racing back toward the Abyssal Hound at the old man’s side.

The demon sensed the danger at once. It reacted almost instantly, trying to leap aside. But the returning Abyssal Deep breath curved in midair like a shell with eyes. It drove straight into the hound’s skull. After a brief delay, the demon made of piled bones exploded into a rain of fragments.

The thin cultist bound to the demon let out a scream. Even though no attack had touched his body, he crumpled to the ground in agony and could not even crawl.

The tide of Shadows surged toward him in a blink, eager to continue the Feast.

“This one is mine,” Agatha’s voice rang out. At the same time, the heavy thud of the Gatekeeper’s cane striking the floor echoed through the dark space. “Leave.”

The Shadows all around them turned wild at once. Overwhelming malice and a jumble of eerie sounds rolled like waves through the air, battering the whole domain. Some of the Shadows even edged toward Agatha.

Her expression did not change. She simply raised the Gatekeeper’s cane and slammed it down again.

Another thunderous crash rang through the space.

“Begone.”

After a brief, frozen silence, all the Shadows withdrew like the ebbing tide.

Chapter 378: Trapped

The cluster of shadows in the Spirit Realm faded, and the noisy clamor and overwhelming malice that had filled the entire space quickly dispersed.

Agatha raised her left hand and calmly used her gaze on the gaunt heretic lying at the edge of the triangular area. He curled on the ground in pain. The black chains extending from his body were already broken; smoke and dust rose from the shattered links as they crumbled segment by segment into sand-like powder.

Now that the Abyssal demons bound to him by the symbiotic pact were dead, this heretic's life was also about to end—but for the moment, he could still answer a few questions.

Agatha did not really expect this stubborn heretic to cooperate, but she still walked over slowly and stopped at the edge of the triangle, looking down at the dying cultist.

"You actually managed, right under the Church's nose, to completely corrupt and replace a whole piece of infrastructure, even to the point of replacing every priest there… That surprised me," she said slowly. Her voice seemed to carry a low echo from a tomb; the dizzying sound could wear down most people's will. "How did you do it?"

The dying heretic struggled to lift his head, but only showed a trace of a mocking smile. There was no fear left on that gaunt face. "You guess?"

Agatha was unmoved: "Your nest is inside Frostholm, isn't it?"

“Heh…” The cultist’s head trembled. He braced himself and forced his body to roll so he lay on his back on the pale ground, facing Agatha’s gaze from below. “Don’t waste your effort. So what if it is in Frostholm… You won’t find it… The day you find the sanctuary will be the day we succeed, foolish priest…”

Agatha’s face stayed expressionless. She lightly lifted her Gatekeeper’s cane and tapped the tip against the cultist’s chest: “What are you really trying to do? Corrupt the city-state with that so-called ‘elements’? Or do you imagine you can use those ‘replicas’—things that cannot even keep themselves stable—to replace the living people in the city? What connection do you have with the power in the Deep Sea? Is it related to the Abyssal Trench Project?”

A cluster of pale flame flared at the tip of the Gatekeeper’s cane. The fire seared flesh and soul alike. The agony made the cultist’s whole body twitch and spasm, yet the heretic, already lost in fanatical faith, only clenched his teeth until they ground, glaring at the Gatekeeper before him. The clacking between his teeth squeezed out only a chilling, twisted laugh: “Heh… heh… The promised… is about to descend… No one… no one will escape…”

Agatha finally frowned. She slowly raised her arm, and with the Gatekeeper’s cane she lifted the cultist little by little into the air. The pale flame burned his body, already twisted from his long symbiotic pact with the Abyssal demons, so that he dangled like a tattered rag in a fire.

Her voice was icy, like sound drifting through a crypt: “One last question, you heretics… How can you speak the name of the God of Death?”

Within the pale flame, a smile slowly spread across the skeletal cultist’s face. He seemed especially delighted; when he saw the Church’s

Gatekeeper puzzled by this question, even the pain brought by the Cremation Fire seemed to lessen by half.

“The Abyssal Lord brought us the revelation… All faiths in this world point to the same place… We who have received the revelation have already stepped past those so-called boundaries… Gatekeeper, do you really think your God is any different from the Holy Lord?”

Agatha’s expression changed at once. The cultist before her had dared to mention the Abyssal Lord in the same breath as the God of Death. Such blasphemy sent anger surging through her. Yet in the flames the cultist showed a final, relieved smile, giving her no chance to question him further. He let out his last breath, and what remained of his body quickly crumbled into ash.

“…Just a madman’s ravings, all upside down and twisted.”

Agatha’s face darkened. She slowly lowered the Gatekeeper’s cane. The anger in her heart was still there, but it did not interfere with her judgment. Once she had reined in the surge of emotion, she immediately began to think.

Setting aside his last remarks, where he put the Abyssal Lord on the same level as the God of Death, this cultist who had been obstinate to the end had actually revealed quite a bit of information she could work with.

They did indeed have a “nest” inside Frostholm, and they called this nest a “sanctuary”. That meant it truly was a place for conducting rituals, which matched the information she already had. The sanctuary had also been “hidden” by some special method, making it extremely hard to find, and he had just said that the moment the sanctuary was found would be the moment of their success… So the way that place was concealed was very likely tied to the progress of their ritual. The closer the ritual came to completion, the more obvious its hiding place would become…

Was it because holding the ritual would inevitably leak some kind of aura? Or because revealing the sanctuary itself was a necessary step for the ritual to be completed?

The cultist had also said, “The promised is about to descend.” That probably referred to the ultimate “prophecy” in their belief system: the power of the Abyssal Lord would overturn the Mortal Realm. The Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea, which now lay in the deep layers of the world, would become the new “Mortal Realm”. Those mad annihilationist cultists had always treated the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea as their promised land. There was no doubt about that.

But how would this process actually be carried out? By simply dropping “elements” into the city over and over? That was clearly not enough… Those “replicas” could barely keep themselves stable for long; how could they possibly corrupt an entire city-state?

Unless… those annihilationist cultists had found a way to keep the “replicas” stable for a long time. Unless they could create such an environment—or… turn Frostholm itself into such an environment…

Agatha frowned, cut off her thoughts, and lifted her head to look around.

She was still in the Spirit Realm. The things around her were lit by the pale radiance spilling through the cracks in the ceiling, making every outline hazy. Faint noises rose again from all directions. The ever-hungry Spirit Realm shadows were starting to stir once more—a single Feast was never enough to keep them quiet for long.

The young Gatekeeper shook her head, raised her left hand, and put her own eyeball back into its socket.

The vague noises around her vanished at once. The hazy lights and the black and white space blinked back into color, and the breath of the Mortal

Realm rushed toward her.

Agatha let out a small breath and reached into her clothes for her eye drops, but suddenly her movements froze.

All around her was utterly silent. There was not a single person.

Agatha lifted her head and looked around. She could not see the black-clad guards she had brought, nor the sewage treatment plant administrator who had fled earlier. She could not even see the ash and remains left behind by the three cultists and the dozen or so “replicas”—

In theory, after she destroyed those cultists and “replicas” in the Spirit Realm, their remains should have appeared at the same time in the Mortal Realm.

The silence around her was too eerie. She could not sense the presence of any living person nearby.

Agatha’s brows knit tightly. She rolled her eyes in their sockets, easing the dryness while carefully studying her surroundings, then slowly walked toward the nearby main door.

The slightly rusted metal door was left ajar, as if someone had left in a hurry and not closed it properly.

With creaking sounds, the metal door was pushed open bit by bit.

Beyond the door stretched a long corridor. The gas lamps along it burned steadily and brightly, yet brought none of the warmth or comfort that light should have given.

“Tap… tap… tap…”

The sound of the Gatekeeper’s cane and her heels hitting the floor rang out clear yet hollow in the corridor as Agatha walked forward slowly.

The entire sewage treatment plant was empty.

But she saw no enemies either.

Just like that, she passed straight through the plant area and came out to the open space outside.

The sky was murky. Heavy, chaotic clouds covered the city-state. Only a few weak rays of light seeped between them, just barely enough to show that it was daytime. Every building in sight lay under this dim daylight, wrapped in a cold, deathly, uncanny atmosphere.

Agatha clearly remembered that when she had come to the sewage treatment plant, the weather outside had been bright and clear—the Sun had hung high in the sky and there had not been a single cloud over the city-state.

The Sun?

A trace of doubt suddenly rose in Agatha's heart, and then that hint of doubt tore wide open in her mind into a clear split in her awareness. She suddenly realized something and lifted her head again to study the sky.

Only a sourceless, chaotic glow spread through the sky. There was no celestial body that could be called "the Sun" at all.

Agatha tried hard to recall what the Sun looked like, to recall the very concept of the Sun.

She could not remember. It was as if a heavy curtain had been thrown over her reason, keeping her from recalling what the Sun in her memories had been like. Only one thing remained very clear—there should exist in this world something called "the Sun", something that naturally hung high in the sky, giving off light and heat and shining on all things!

“…cognitive interference, able to affect a Gatekeeper… The intensity is astonishing, and it covers the entire environment…” Agatha murmured to herself. After a brief moment of shock, she quickly calmed down again and looked around once more.

“It’s an Otherworld.”

Chapter 379: Confronting the Madman

Agatha walked along the cold, deserted street. The cityscape she knew so well now seemed filled everywhere with a silent, eerie air. In the shadows between buildings and behind tightly shut doors and windows, it felt as if pairs of eyes were hiding, spying on her.

She was searching for a way out of this Otherworld—or for the culprit who had trapped her here.

Any place that looked out of place might be a rift where it intersected with the Mortal Realm, yet so far she had not found such a rift anywhere in this eerie “Frostholm city-state”.

There was only one thing she was sure of: she had already touched the shadows that had been shrouding the city-state all this time. Whether by accident or by the hidden hand of the mastermind, she had managed to cross the “screen” that had always blocked her sight.

This place that looked like Frostholm yet was not Frostholm had to be the source of the strange incidents that had plagued the city-state lately.

From far away came the sound of wheels rolling over cobblestones, faint jingling of carriage bells, and the noise of doors opening and closing.

Agatha raised her head toward the direction of the sounds, yet saw only an empty street. But a little farther away, she could indeed see shadowy shapes

like carriages flashing past at intersections, and figures like pedestrians hurrying across those distant crossings.

There were “people” in this city, but most of the time she could only see distant phantoms. Here she could hear the voices of residents, but could rarely locate exactly where those sounds came from.

It was like a gaudy, distorted, twisted dream.

Agatha’s figure passed through yet another intersection, then stopped in the shadows between buildings.

Blind wandering would only waste her strength and time. She needed to judge her surroundings carefully.

She closed her eyes and let her senses spread out around her, carefully picking out all the details in the environment—sounds, smells, the direction of the wind, and… the warmth of living people.

After a moment, Agatha lifted her head toward a certain direction and started walking that way. Her eyes were still closed, yet she avoided every obstacle in her path as if she could see everything clearly. She threaded through alleys, passed junction after junction and side street, and did not know how long she walked before she stopped in front of a building at a street corner.

Agatha opened her eyes and saw a small restaurant before her. Its lamps were blazing inside, and lively voices came from within.

The sounds were very real. She could feel the presence of living people inside.

Agatha steadied herself and went up to push open the restaurant door.

A clear bell rang as the door opened, and the scene inside the restaurant rushed into view. For a moment Agatha felt dazed. She even wondered if

she had already left that strange Otherworld and returned to the normal Mortal Realm.

The restaurant was brightly lit. Guests could be seen eating at tables everywhere, while servers busied themselves back and forth between the tables and the counter. The shop assistant in charge of greeting customers was working behind the counter. At her ears rang the clear clink of knives, forks, cups, and plates, as well as people chatting about the weather, their work, and prices. The cold, deathly air she had soaked up out on the street seemed swept away by this bustling “worldly scene”.

Yet the next second, Agatha noticed something deeply wrong here. Though the diners were eating at their tables, every cup and plate in front of them was empty. Though the shop assistant bustled behind the counter, he only paced back and forth in place, wiping the same cup over and over.

Everyone was like an automaton with its program set in advance, just repeating the actions that ordinary people should have in daily life—only… their imitation was eerily lifelike.

Agatha frowned. Once she sensed the truth, the atmosphere here felt even more uncanny than the empty street outside. But she did not turn to leave. Instead, she stepped further into the shop.

The stranger a place was, the more it meant she was on the right track.

With Agatha’s first step, the lively chatter inside the restaurant suddenly stopped.

All the diners who had been talking closed their mouths at the same time, yet the expressions from their conversations still remained on their faces, and their hands still held the motions of eating. In the wide space, once the voices were gone, only the monotonous clatter of cups, plates, and cutlery remained.

When Agatha took her second step, the clatter of cups and cutlery vanished as well. Everyone in the restaurant stopped moving, as if their power had been suddenly cut off, and froze beside the square tables.

As Agatha took her third step, everyone in the restaurant put down their knives and forks. They rose like zombies and turned their heads, dozens of empty gazes falling on her.

Agatha looked toward the counter in front of her. The shop assistant who had been wiping the same cup at last stopped as well. But unlike the zombie-like diners around him, this shop assistant slowly lifted his head, and when he looked at Agatha there was a faint smile on his face.

The smile even seemed a little friendly.

“Hello, Miss Gatekeeper,” the shop assistant spoke. He was a young man with short blond hair and a rather decent face, wearing a white shirt and a black jacket. He was polite as he talked, as if he really were serving a guest who had just walked in: “I’m very glad you could visit us. What do you think of this delightful city?”

“It seems you’re the one behind all this,” Agatha said calmly, fixing her gaze on the blond “shop assistant” before her. “Finding you was a bit easier than I expected.”

“Or perhaps not as easy as you imagine,” the blond young man laughed. “Would you like something? Contaminated sewage? Bread made of dirt? Or… an empty bowl? We have plenty of those here.”

Agatha had no intention of answering. She simply raised her Gatekeeper’s cane and swept it through the air.

In an instant, the blond young man behind the counter was wrapped layer upon layer in pale flame that appeared out of thin air. Within a few breaths, that shell of flesh was burned to ash by the Gatekeeper’s Cremation Fire.

Only a scattering of gray-white bone ash drifted down and settled on the counter.

Yet Agatha's expression did not change at all, because before the flames had even flared, she had already sensed that there was no living aura inside that young man.

A strange squelching of viscous matter sounded from the side. Agatha turned her head and saw one of the stiffly standing "diners" by a nearby table suddenly begin to tremble all over. In the next second his body melted like wax. Black, muddy substance surged and shifted over his surface, and within a few breaths that diner had changed into a blond young man in a white shirt and black jacket.

"What an unfriendly way to say hello," the blond young man said, brushing dust from his clothes and looking at Agatha with a hint of helplessness. "Miss Gatekeeper, you don't really think that would get rid of me, do you? Do you think I would recklessly expose my true body in a place this dangerous?"

"I know you're not here," Agatha said without changing expression, "but at least this can make you stop your noise for a while."

"All right, all right, it seems you're not in the mood to chat—you're a dull woman. By comparison, that Professor Merson was much more interesting in his final moments," the blond young man said with a shrug. "But that's fine. As long as you stay here quietly for a while, I don't mind if you're a boring prisoner."

The instant she heard the words "Professor Merson", Agatha's expression changed slightly. She thought of the vanished Dagger Island, and of the reports that spoke of a series of explosions there just before the island disappeared. Then she caught the information hidden in the last few sentences he had said.

“What did you mean by those last words?” She fixed her gaze on the blond young man before her and spoke in an icy tone.

“Nothing much, I’m only asking you to stay here as a guest for a while,” the blond young man said, smiling brightly. “You don’t need to worry about the situation ‘up there’—soon, another you will return there. She will gather the guardians just like you did and compile a report based on the actual situation at the sewage treatment plant…

“Don’t worry, she will report everything faithfully, including the corruption at the plant and the replacement of its staff. Then, just as you usually do, she will return to the Cathedral to make her report and speak with Bishop Ivan. After that, she will patrol the city-state, continue handling all the problems it faces, and continue the investigations you failed to finish… Nothing will be delayed.”

Agatha’s face finally turned completely cold. She stared hard at the blond young man before her: “You even made a ‘replica’ of a Gatekeeper?!”

“Is that so hard?” The blond young man slowly withdrew his smile and looked at Agatha with a faintly mocking gaze. “Of course, she doesn’t have your power. But aside from that, she has no flaws. She is even more perfect than any replica we have ever made before—do you know just how perfect? She… doesn’t even know she’s fake.”

Agatha’s face was like frost. The knuckles of the hand gripping her Gatekeeper’s cane turned slightly white. “You can’t fool the Cathedral with a replica—there are countless sharp eyes there.”

“Countless sharp eyes—mortal eyes,” the blond young man said unhurriedly, meeting Agatha’s icy gaze without a hint of fear. “You are overestimating your colleagues. And speaking of replicas… do you truly think that you and the others are any different from the ‘replicas’ you talk about?”

He smiled again and slowly raised both hands, like a preaching Saint revealing the truth of the world: “Miss Gatekeeper, from the very beginning there has never been any such thing as a replica—or rather… we are all replicas. That is the truth.”

Chapter 380: Island in the Mist

The island was getting closer. The thick fog around it, and the silhouettes inside the fog, also became clearer and clearer. Lawrence stood on the foredeck of the White Oak, both hands gripping the rail in front of him so hard that his knuckles had gone pale.

Anyone would have been nervous. Even an old captain who had spent half his life drifting on the Boundless Sea was no exception. What would they find on that island? What were those shadows in the dense fog? Why did the island appear around the White Oak again and again, almost as if it had a mind of its own? And most important of all… what was this stretch of sea, wrapped in so many strange phenomena?

Lawrence took a deep breath. The cold air rushed into his lungs and forced his restless thoughts to calm down. He tried hard not to think about other Anomalies, such as Martha appearing in front of him, and the eerie fact that other people could also see Martha. He knew he had to cut off that line of thought, because all of this was clearly tied to his worsening mental state. If he kept thinking about it, Martha might really become something more than a phantom.

He had no potion left. Even if he had some, the draught had clearly lost its effect.

The steam core was running steadily as the White Oak slowly closed in on the small island with its twisted shoreline. The beautiful white ship glided across the surface of the sea and left a long wake behind it. In the rippling

waves spreading out from that wake, a faint ghostly green flashed by for an instant.

No one noticed what was happening at the stern. Everyone on the ship was focused on the strange little island.

The edges of the island were steep and jagged, full of sharp rocks and cliffs. There was nowhere suitable to come alongside. The experienced helmsman did not rashly bring the ship straight in. Instead, he steered the White Oak into a slow circle around the island.

When they had gone about a third of the way around, the sailor in the lookout post suddenly spotted something.

“There is a harbor!” the sailor shouted from the high platform.

A moment later, a small pier came into Lawrence’s view. The facilities deeper inside the pier were covered by fog, so he could not see them clearly, but the part that stretched out into the sea was still visible. That part looked complete, with no sign of damage.

An intact pier meant they could bring the White Oak in to dock instead of using a small boat to land. That would clearly make exploring the island safer. Besides easier supplies and a faster retreat, the few small-caliber escort guns mounted on the White Oak could also provide cover for any operation along the shore.

Lawrence returned to the bridge. Under his command, the White Oak began to move carefully toward the empty pier. Because there were no mental guidance personnel on the shore to assist them, the whole docking process was very slow, but in the end it was completed safely.

Lawrence looked to the far side of the pier. Fog covered the island. Even the nearby pier facilities looked hazy in the mist. He was not sure if it was

just his imagination, but he felt that the fog on this island was even thicker than before.

“I don’t see anyone,” the First Mate came to stand beside Lawrence, watching the island as he spoke. “But I can faintly see some lights… they seem to be coming from the harbor buildings.”

“Anything on the radio?”

“No. After we got close to this island, we even lost the Frostholm signal that we were always able to receive,” the First Mate shook his head. “We also got no reply from the light-signal.”

Lawrence thought for a moment. “Go pick twelve sharp and cautious sailors, arm them, and come ashore with me to explore.”

“You are going ashore in person?” The First Mate was startled. “This island looks very strange. If you go yourself, there might be…”

“Risk? I am afraid the risk is the same if I stay on the ship,” Lawrence shook his head. “What is strange is not only this island, but this whole stretch of sea. We are trapped inside a large Vision. Inside the range of a Vision, danger is everywhere. Going ashore at least gives us a chance to find useful information.”

The First Mate opened his mouth, but he had to admit that the captain’s experience and judgment both made sense.

“Alright, I will go get ready.”

After a while, the First Mate picked out twelve suitable sailors from among the crew members. They were all veteran seafarers with many years of experience, men of firm will and devout faith. Together with the First Mate himself, that made thirteen people getting ready to go ashore with Lawrence.

The duties of holding the White Oak were temporarily handed over to the Second Mate.

The rope ladder was lowered to the pier's jetty. Lawrence led his small exploration party down the ladder and stepped onto the mysterious island wrapped in mist.

The solid ground under their feet eased some of the unease in the explorers' hearts. Lawrence stood on the pier, stamped hard on the ground, then turned back and muttered: "At least this concrete is real."

"The lights are that way," the First Mate said. He held a large-caliber rifle in his hands and lifted his head to look ahead. "We can still see them here, but I still don't see any sign of people moving around."

"Do not split up. Do not touch anything you do not recognize. If you hear a voice around you calling to you, do not answer until you know where the voice is coming from and where your teammates are," Lawrence said in a very serious tone. "If you see anything suspicious in the fog, warn everyone at once. Do not open fire on your own and do not break away from the group to explore."

He paused, then swept his gaze over the team he had brought.

Twelve sailors, one First Mate, and himself.

"Finally, remember this. There are only fourteen of us. Before we return to the ship, we may have fewer men, but we must never have more."

The sailors answered at once: "Yes, Captain!"

Lawrence nodded and led the team into the thick fog.

They crossed the pier's jetty and came to an open area. It looked like a place for temporary cargo stacking. Some remains of storage sheds and

small lifting equipment were still visible, but aside from these facilities, they still did not see a single human figure.

“This does not look like it has been abandoned for long,” the First Mate muttered as he studied the area around them. “It looks like it was a busy harbor only a few days ago.”

Lawrence stayed silent. He studied the nearby harbor facilities, and suddenly his gaze fell on a metal plaque.

“Dagger Island Harbor Supplies.”

Dagger Island. That was the name of this island.

“This is Dagger Island?” The First Mate came over and read the letters on the plaque, surprise in his eyes. “I have heard of this place… it is a small island near the city-state of Frostholm. It used to produce Boiling Gold, but I heard it was turned into a military facility years ago… is this really Dagger Island?”

“Nothing here can be trusted. We just moored for a while in a place that looked very much like Frostholm,” Lawrence shook his head. “Let’s keep moving. The light we saw should be coming from the harbor office. There might be something there that can answer our questions.”

The exploration party left the pier’s storage area and started up a sloping path toward the lamp shining in the fog. Everyone’s nerves were tight. They watched every shift in the mist around them.

A very light wind blew here and there over the island. It stirred the gray-white fog so it slowly rolled and curled. The strange silhouettes that showed faintly in the distance seemed to move with it, swaying slightly like living things. In that dim and chaotic fog, the lamp grew brighter and brighter and slowly drew closer in everyone’s sight.

The First Mate, walking at the front of the line, suddenly stopped.

“What is this?” The First Mate lowered his head and frowned at a strange pile by the side of the path.

Lawrence held a revolver in one hand and a consecrated lantern in the other. He walked up to the First Mate and finally saw that pile of stuff.

It looked like a heap of gray-black mud. It had already dried. The edges were cracked like scales, but he could still see traces of how it had flowed a moment before it dried.

It was as if a mass of boiling, bubbling slime had suddenly had all its water sucked out in the next instant.

“Silt?” Lawrence frowned and did not dare touch the strange thing. “Why would there be silt here?”

“I think I saw something similar back at the pier, some black sludge,” a sailor said, not very sure. “But back there it was mixed in with a pile of junk, so I just thought it was garbage…”

Lawrence nodded. Right after that, another sailor suddenly shouted: “There is another pile here!”

Lawrence turned toward the voice and saw another heap of black sludge on the other side of the path.

Was this stuff all over the island?

Unease spread in everyone’s hearts, but no one could answer what that mud really was. Lawrence pulled the team in tighter and had everyone avoid contact with the strange “silt.” Then they continued forward into the depths of the fog.

After a while, they finally reached the end of the slope. Just as Lawrence had guessed, this was where the harbor office stood.

A small building of reinforced concrete stood here. Faint yellow light spilled out of its windows, yet no sound came from inside.

The main door of the building was slightly ajar. A plaque was nailed to it. On it were the words: “Harbor General Office.”

Lawrence stepped up to the door and pressed his ear against it, listening for any sound from within. Then he got ready to push it open.

But suddenly, he froze.

On the wall beside the door, a line of marks caught his eye. They looked as if someone had rushed to carve them with a dagger. Together they formed a single sentence.

“Humans have only two eyes!”

Chapter 381: Cannon Fire

When he saw that rough and sharp line of letters, Lawrence and the First Mate both froze.

"'Humans have only two eyes'… why is this carved here?" The First Mate stared at the words for a long time with wide eyes before he turned his head in confusion. "Isn't that just normal? Except for a very few people born with deformities, who doesn't have two eyes?"

Lawrence did not answer at once. He stayed silent for a long time before he finally broke the silence. "Who do you think carved this line?"

"…The natives of the island?" the First Mate guessed, unsure. "Someone used to live on this island?"

"I am not sure about this island, but Dagger Island in the Mortal Realm definitely has people," Lawrence said slowly. He reached out and gently touched the cuts on the wall. The rough, solid feel against his fingers seemed to carry the strong emotion and will of the person who carved the phrase. "Humans have only two eyes. Someone carved this sentence on the wall on purpose. That might mean one thing…"

"It might mean one thing?"

"That on this island there once appeared things that were not 'only two eyes,' things that looked like humans," Lawrence slowly lifted his head and looked into the fog around them and the vague shapes within it. "And they mixed in among humans and could not be easily noticed."

The First Mate drew in a sharp breath and spoke with some hesitation. “Then… where did the person who carved this sentence go?”

“I do not know,” Lawrence shook his head. For some reason, he thought of the black sludge he had seen along the way and of the empty pier, but he pushed these vague guesses aside for now. He put his hand on the handle of the harbor office door. “Stay alert.”

The sound of safeties clicking off came from behind him. Lawrence steadied himself, then pushed the door open with a firm shove.

He quickly stepped to the side so he would not present his body to whatever might be hiding inside. The First Mate stepped half a pace forward, lowering himself into a crouch and pointing his rifle into the room. The sailors behind them raised their guns as well, aiming at the open doorway from different angles.

There was no movement inside the building.

The First Mate took a breath and carefully leaned forward to look through the doorway.

“There is no one inside,” he said over his shoulder. “It is an empty office with the lights on.”

Lawrence waved to the sailors, then entered the room with the First Mate leading the way.

It was an empty office. Several desks took up almost half the space. A few chairs stood in front of them, placed as if people had only just stood up from them a moment before. The electric lights on the ceiling and the gas lamps on the walls were still lit, making the room very bright. On the floor… that same strange, suspicious black sludge could be seen everywhere.

“This disgusting stuff is all over here too…” The First Mate frowned at the black substance on the floor, his face full of disgust. He carefully stepped around the dried mud and came to the desks. His eyes moved over the messy piles of papers and office items. “These things… Captain, do you want to take a look?”

“These are the forms and reports the harbor had to handle every day. Cargo in and out, personnel transfers, facility inspections, and equipment check reports…” Lawrence came up to the desks and looked through a few documents. His brow furrowed deeper and deeper. “The dates… they are from just a few days ago?”

“It feels like people were still working here not long ago,” a sailor said with a nervous gulp. “Then they all rushed to evacuate and didn’t even have time to pack up…”

“Rushed to evacuate?” Lawrence muttered under his breath. His gaze swept across the desk. A half cup of coffee sat there, not yet finished, with a thin layer of dust on its surface. Beside that desk, a patch of black sludge on the floor had already dried. A bit of the black stuff even clung to the chair. His expression grew more and more grim. “Was it really an evacuation…”

The First Mate heard the change in his tone. “Captain, what did you think of?”

Lawrence thought for a moment and was just about to speak when a harsh noise suddenly came from outside the room. It sounded like it came from the direction of the harbor square. It was the electric hiss of a loudspeaker suddenly switching on.

“Bzz…”

The shrill noise startled everyone. The sailors quickly turned their eyes to the window. The next second, a broken, twisted broadcast voice, full of

interference, rang out over the whole harbor district. It sounded like an older man's voice. "Notice… we have been touched by corruption… this island… can no longer be saved… Protocol Twenty-Two will be activated… it was an honor to work with you all… we will meet again behind Bartok's gate."

After another burst of static, the broadcast from the square cut off. The First Mate stared in shock and turned back to Lawrence. "Captain, what was that…"

Before he could finish, a thunderous roar boomed from far away.

More thunder followed, one blast after another, like the sky and earth were splitting apart.

The chain of explosions swept across the whole of Dagger Island in an instant and shook everyone to the core. Lawrence almost understood what was happening the moment the blasts began.

That was not thunder. It was explosives. Some facility on the island was blowing itself up.

"Get out of the building!" Lawrence suddenly shouted. He fired his pistol at the ceiling. "There are explosives!"

The sound of his shout was almost buried by the explosion noise, but the gunshot was enough to snap the sailors out of it. They rushed for the door at once.

A dozen men burst through the doorway, ran down the slope, and sprinted toward the open ground. The explosions still rumbled from all directions, as if the whole island was being ripped to pieces. But halfway down, Lawrence suddenly felt that something was wrong.

"Stop!" He halted all at once, firing into the air again as he yelled. "Stop!"

The sailors stumbled to a halt. Then they too noticed what was wrong.

There were only explosions in their ears. In the direction of the blasts, there were no clouds of smoke, no flashes of light, and not even the faintest tremor under their feet.

Only the thunder-like noise echoed over the whole island.

After a while, the sound slowly faded away. The island returned to the same foggy silence as before. It was as if the earth-shattering bombardment had been nothing but a shared hallucination.

“Only sound?” The First Mate stared around in shock, unable to believe it.

“It was an echo,” Lawrence’s heartbeat slowly calmed as he forced himself to a decision. He did not know if he was right, but as captain he had to give everyone an answer. “What we just heard was something that once happened on this island, replaying as a lingering echo in our ears. It was not a real explosion.”

“I was scared half to death just now,” a sailor muttered. “I thought it was a real blast…”

“The closest explosion just now came from that direction,” the First Mate said. He lifted his head to check their surroundings, then pointed to the other side of the harbor square. “Should we go over there and take a look?”

“Let’s go see what is there,” Lawrence decided quickly. “If something really happened here, there should still be traces left.”

The exploration party moved into the dense fog again, now more cautious than before.

After an unknown amount of time, the ruins of a large building appeared before Lawrence.

The building stood at the inner edge of a small bay, backed by a sheer wall of rock. From the damage, it was clear that a massive explosion from the inside out had completely destroyed it.

The First Mate stood on a higher spot and stared at the ruins in shock.

“What kind of facility was this… it is incredible…”

“We should be more curious about what terrible thing happened here, so terrible that they would blow up a facility like this without hesitation,” Lawrence said in a low voice. He took a few steps forward. “If the people on this island…”

“Stop.”

A voice suddenly spoke from nearby, and Lawrence’s feet stopped at once.

“Martha?!”

He snapped his head toward the direction of the voice, calling out in alarm.

But there was only the slowly rising and falling fog there, with no sign of that familiar figure.

“Captain?” The First Mate noticed the captain’s strange reaction. He jumped down from a rock and hurried to Lawrence’s side. “What happened?”

“…An auditory hallucination,” Lawrence answered at once, his face very serious. “You did not hear a voice, did you?”

“We did not hear anything.” The sailors looked at one another. One of them answered for the group.

“We may not want to go any deeper,” Lawrence said with a frown. “We should go back to the harbor first, then…”

Martha’s voice came into his ear again, this time closer. “Go back to the ship. Now.”

Lawrence froze for a moment and forced himself not to look toward the sound. He wanted to keep talking, but a second later Martha’s voice came once more, this time almost at his ear, with a hint of urgency. “Get back on the White Oak. At once – Lawrence, they are coming!”

Lawrence’s eyes widened a little. He spoke without thinking. “Who? Who is coming?”

Beside him, the First Mate grabbed Lawrence’s arm in worry. “Captain, who are you talking to?”

Lawrence did not answer. He suddenly lifted his head and looked toward the direction where the White Oak was docked.

A wave of unease surged in his heart.

The next second, as if to prove that unease right, a heavy, muffled thunder came from that direction.

It was the sound of guns.

“Someone is firing the guns…” The First Mate reacted at once. “We have an enemy!”

“Back to the ship!” Lawrence shouted. He led the team and ran at full speed toward the harbor. In the rush of wind past his ears, Martha’s voice brushed against his ear like a whisper.

“The Sea Swallow is here…”

Chapter 382: Flames Flared Up

Lawrence ran at full speed, yet he still could not help turning his head to look toward the direction of Martha’s voice.

However, he saw nothing but the lingering thick fog over Dagger Island. The voice seemed to ring straight in his mind, urging him again and again to leave the island, to return to the White Oak, to leave this place and go to Frostholm.

Martha was of course not here.

But Lawrence still felt it was some kind of unseen guidance. Maybe it came from his faith. Maybe it came from his subconscious, from clues and instincts he had never noticed. They pushed him toward a way out of this trap.

He ran toward the harbor. Cold wind and fog slapped his face and howled past his ears. His first mate and the sailors surrounded him. Gunfire still rolled from far away. Some blasts came from the distant shore guns, and some from the light escort cannons mounted on the White Oak. The White Oak’s return fire sounded weak compared to the enemy’s attack. It was clearly at a disadvantage.

“Martha” had told him the Sea Swallow was here. But which ship was the Sea Swallow?

The harbor came into view. At the far edge of the fog, the graceful hull of the White Oak still lay moored at the end of the pier. Bursts of fire flashed again and again at her bow and stern. Each cannon blast tore the mist apart.

Out on the nearby sea, huge columns of water rose into the air from time to time. That was clearly the enemy's bombardment.

"The ship is still there!" The first mate shouted with joy when he saw the White Oak. He called out for the captain and also to rally the gasping sailors: "Jason didn't abandon us!"

Jason was the ship's second mate.

"Storm Goddess above! Get aboard and get out of this cursed place!" a sailor yelled. "The White Oak is just sitting here as a target!"

The group rushed toward the White Oak. Figures moved on the ship. The seafarers left on watch had clearly seen the captain's party returning. A rope ladder dropped from the rail. Two sailors at the edge of the deck raised consecrated lanterns and waved them anxiously in the air.

The sailors who had gone ashore sprinted toward the rope ladder.

But suddenly, Lawrence stopped. He yanked out his revolver and fired into the sky: "Stop, all of you!"

The sailors froze at the gunshot and at the captain's shout. Shocked and confused, they stopped and turned to stare at one another. First Mate Gus also stopped and looked at the old captain, puzzled. Less than a second later, the experienced seafarer understood why the captain had suddenly ordered them to halt.

The first mate panted for breath. Amid the endless thunder of the guns, he lifted his head and looked around. His gaze swept quickly over the sailors around him and over Lawrence.

Sixteen sailors stood around him, looking lost. Every face looked familiar. Captain Lawrence watched them with a grave expression.

“How many people did we bring when we set out?” Lawrence asked quickly.

“Besides you and me, there were…” The first mate started fast, but his mind went blank when he reached the number. He paused for a second or two, then remembered. “Twelve sailors!”

Lawrence’s gaze grew heavier as he looked over the group, counting them one by one in his mind.

Deep in his pupils, a faint green light seemed to flicker on and off.

“There are four extra,” the first mate said after finishing his own count. The old seafarer’s face turned very serious. He raised his gun and fired into the air, then shouted: “Everyone, spread out one meter apart! Face the captain! Keep your hands where we can see them!”

The sailors also realized what was happening. Their faces tightened with fear. But they had dealt with the Boundless Sea for many years and were experienced seafarers. They knew what to do at a time like this. Under the first mate’s orders, the sixteen sailors quickly spread out into a line.

The guns on the White Oak kept firing. More and more columns of water rose around the harbor. The enemy called the Sea Swallow seemed to be drawing closer. Lawrence’s thoughts boiled in the roar of the cannons.

They could not stay here. The White Oak was a sitting target in the harbor. Its weak self-defense guns and hull would not last long. But he could not take this group back on board either, because some “things” from the island had clearly slipped into their ranks. If he brought them back, the White Oak would not end any better than being sunk by artillery.

His gaze swept over the sixteen sailors in front of him as he tried hard to spot any strange or out-of-place face. When had the four extra people slipped in? While they crossed the thick fog? In the harbor office? Or in that

moment on the island when the explosions went off and the group fell into brief chaos?

The sailors also looked one another over. In that moment, it felt as if no one was trustworthy anymore. Even their own memories and judgment seemed doubtful.

“Captain.” Gus’s voice reached Lawrence’s ears. The old seafarer’s face showed a grim resolve. “The White Oak can’t stay here any longer. You should get on board.”

Lawrence’s face suddenly grew extremely serious. “What do you mean?”

“You take the ship and leave. The rest of us will stay. We will slowly find a way to pick out whatever slipped in and deal with it. When you are safe, you can come back for us…”

Lawrence stared into the first mate’s eyes, his expression dark and silent.

That talk about coming back for them once it was safe fooled no one.

Once the White Oak left the harbor, anyone left on the island would be abandoned for good. The strange events here were plain to see. In such a short time, four unknown “things” had slipped into their ranks. What else could come from staying?

“Don’t rush to sacrifice yourselves,” Lawrence said softly. Suddenly he remembered something, and his eyes changed. “Humans have only two eyes…”

His gaze stopped on one sailor.

Then on a second, a third, and a fourth.

One of the sailors pointed at himself in surprise. He blinked his eyes, then blinked his third and fourth eyes as well. “Don’t I have two eyes?”

Lawrence said nothing. He simply raised his revolver.

The second to raise his gun was First Mate Gus. Then the other sailors seemed to wake from a dream.

It felt as if they had all stepped through a Veil. As the cognitive interference clouding their minds broke, they stared in shock and fear at the figures standing among their ranks, the ones that only looked like humans. One by one, they raised their pistols and rifles.

The four not-quite-human “sailors” were surrounded. They stood there in confusion. Then their expressions turned dull and blank.

It was as if the temporary, copied minds inside them had been struck and shattered. The not-quite-human replicas swayed and looked up one by one at their “captain.”

Lawrence could only let out a long sigh: “You are not members of my crew.”

The next second, under his own stunned gaze, he saw a tuft of pale green fire suddenly bloom in the air.

At first it was only a few sparks. They flickered into view between the twelve real sailors like sparks between the poles of an electrical device. In an instant, those sparks exploded and grew into great sheets of flame. The ghostly green fire of spirit form burned fiercely among the men and then lunged toward the four dazed replicas like a predator that had smelled prey.

The flames roared and crackled. The four replicas thrashed in the blaze, but they had no time even to scream. They turned into patches of black dust, the ash left after burning. It faintly looked like the black sludge they had seen earlier on the slope by the harbor, but it was drier and more powdery.

The sailors were terrified. The instant the spirit form flames ignited, everyone from the White Oak remembered scenes of past horror. They

remembered the moment of terror when they met the Vanished on the Boundless Sea. They remembered the shocking sight of a city melted by fire in Pland. They knew this fire far too well.

Why was this fire here?

Was Captain Duncan nearby?

But just as that frightening guess burst in each of their hearts and the sailors began to panic, the fire suddenly went out. It vanished as quickly as it had appeared. When the four replicas turned to ash, the ghostly green spirit form flames disappeared without a trace.

What remained were a group of shaken, terrified sailors, a first mate struck dumb, and an old captain who really felt he should have retired long ago.

“Wh… what was that just now?” First Mate Gus turned his head with effort and swallowed hard. “Captain, that fire, it looked like…”

“It was the Vanished’s power. The Vanished…” Lawrence swallowed and suddenly looked up toward the sea, as if trying to spot that ghost ship. But he saw only the White Oak, still wrapped in thunderous gunfire. The sailors who had been waving the consecrated lanterns at the rail were nowhere to be seen. Everyone had probably already thrown themselves into the battle.

The seafarers on the White Oak were fighting with all their might, buying time for the captain’s group to board.

The Vanished was not here, but Captain Duncan’s fire had appeared before them all.

“Do not panic,” Lawrence said quickly, trying to calm the sailors. “We have already met the Vanished once. The city-state of Pland was even saved by that ship. It might not be a bad thing. Haven’t you heard the rumor? They say Captain Duncan Abnomar has already found his humanity again…”

The first mate made a small gesture of prayer to the Storm Goddess, then asked: “Captain, then should we go back to the ship now?”

“…Go back. Quickly. Before more strange things slip in.”

Chapter 383: Anomaly 077

The cannons roared. Scorching shells screamed down from the sky. Huge columns of water rose again and again inside and outside the harbor. Some pillars almost grazed the White Oak’s hull. The sea churned and heaved. The whole ship shook from the impacts and gave off worrying creaks.

Lawrence and First Mate Gus led the twelve sailors up the rope ladder and, with some scares but no accidents, climbed back onto the White Oak’s deck. Behind them, Dagger Island was still buried in thick fog. Over the empty harbor, a chaotic wind suddenly rose. The fog rolled and twisted in the gusts, as if full of malice, as if angered by uninvited guests.

The boatswain ran over in a rush. The tall seafarer’s face was tight with worry. He clutched a rifle in his hands, even though it was almost useless in a sea battle. He stopped in front of Lawrence, quickly checked the captain’s condition, and finally let out a breath. “Good! You are finally back. We heard thunder-like sounds from the island, and you still were not returning. The second mate thought something had happened to you…”

Scenes from the plaza by the docks flashed through Lawrence’s mind. He remembered the four extra sailors and the sudden green flames. A complicated look came to his face.

Something had happened, and it was no small thing. But this was clearly not the time to explain.

“Leave that for now,” he said, shaking his head. “What is the situation? Where is Jason?”

“The second mate is on the bridge, commanding the fight. We are trading fire with an unknown warship,” the boatswain said quickly. “The moment that ship showed up in the distance, it opened fire on us and has been closing in ever since. The stern took a hit just now. Luckily the damage is not too bad, but we have to get out of here. The White Oak cannot match a warship.”

“Leave this place. Now,” Lawrence said at once.

The steam core gave a low roar as the Boiling Gold catalyst began to release its surging power. The strong propulsion system drove the propellers, pushing the White Oak to speed up and leave the eerie harbor. Between the falling columns of water from the nearby shells, the advanced white-hulled cargo and exploration ship kept accelerating and left Dagger Island behind in the fog.

However, the attacker did not give up the chase.

Lawrence went up to the bridge and watched the sea through the wide side window. At the far edge of the misty ocean, he saw the outline of their attacker clearly. It was a warship that was not especially large. It chased them while the main gun at its bow kept firing, bright flashes stabbing again and again through the dark sky that covered the whole area.

Fortunately, it was a small ship and not a heavily armed battleship. Otherwise the White Oak could never have lasted this long.

Unfortunately, that ship was very fast. Even as the White Oak’s speed kept rising, Lawrence could tell it would catch up sooner or later.

It was even still speeding up.

“We cannot shake it,” the first mate said, his tone close to despair. “It is too fast… and our guns could never match a warship’s.”

Lawrence did not answer. He just thought quickly.

By category, the White Oak was indeed a civilian vessel, but that did not mean it was a sheep waiting for slaughter. As a special-purpose exploration ship that could sail the Boundless Sea for long periods and carry sealed objects between city-states, it had a military-grade steam core and an anti-sinking structure. Its keel, hull at the waterline, and superstructure had all been specially reinforced. In terms of hull strength alone, it was no weaker than a warship of the same size.

What it lacked was firepower. As a civilian ship, it could only mount a few small-caliber guns meant to fight off small bands of pirates or sea monsters. Those guns were no match for a warship’s artillery.

From the look of things, the White Oak would be overtaken sooner or later. Once the distance shrank, the enemy’s shots would not miss so often.

No matter how strong a hull was, it could not last long as a target under constant fire.

A sharp whistling sound rushed toward them from afar. The booming crash that followed cut off Lawrence’s thoughts. His ears rang and the deck shook under his feet. Out of the corner of his eye he saw a fireball blossom along the White Oak’s side as broken metal and deck planks flew apart.

The boatswain shouted: “Hit on the side! Put out the fire!”

Lawrence steadied himself on the rocking deck. His expression changed quickly, as if he had made a decision.

“The cargo manifest,” he said, lifting his head to the first mate who was keeping order on the bridge. “Bring me the cargo manifest.”

“The cargo manifest?” The first mate hesitated for a moment, then understood what the captain meant. His face became very conflicted and grim, but he still obeyed at once and brought a logbook to Lawrence.

Lawrence opened the book and scanned it quickly, then stopped on one line.

“Open sealed vault Two. Bring sealed object Anomaly 077 to the bridge,” he said, looking up and issuing the order. “Prepare a clean shroud and a new noose. Be ready to reseal it at any time.”

The first mate’s face tightened. He had already guessed this might happen, yet he still hesitated. “Captain, this…”

“The situation is urgent. We have no other choice,” Lawrence said sternly. “There is precedent for unsealing a sealed object on board to solve a crisis. If the Church wants to hold someone responsible later, I will explain it to them.”

The first mate seemed about to say more, but under the old captain’s serious gaze he swallowed his words and nodded hard. “Yes, Captain.”

The order was carried out quickly. Several seafarers assigned to handle sealed objects ran to a special section below decks, opened sealed vault Two, and lifted the room’s seal according to Anomaly 077’s containment rules.

Moments later, amid the thunder of the guns, several sailors carried Anomaly 077 onto the bridge and set the item the captain had asked for before Lawrence.

Lawrence lowered his head and stared at the Anomaly the sailors had brought from the sealed vault, his expression very grave.

It was a mummified corpse tightly wrapped in the shroud.

It was Anomaly 077, the Sailor.

Lawrence knew the details of every piece of cargo in his ship’s hold. That naturally included this Anomaly.

Anomaly 077 had first been found on an exploration ship that had mysteriously vanished for three years. It was believed to be the main cause

of that ship’s loss. On the outside, this Anomaly looked like a mummified corpse about 1.7 meters tall. When unsealed, it behaved like a living being, able to think and speak with people. Its power matched its “identity” very closely.

As a “sailor,” it tried to influence the ship closest to it, ignoring all environmental conditions, ship types, or control systems. In a short time it could take over all of a vessel’s functions. Once it had full control, it would make the ship perform a random teleportation. In just a few minutes, any ship, no matter its size, would be sent to a random corner of the Boundless Sea under the Sailor’s influence.

But that teleportation was no calm journey. Any ship teleported by Anomaly 077 would appear at the heart of a great storm.

No one knew whether Anomaly 077 chose storms on purpose as the landing points for its teleportations or created a storm just for the jump. The only certain thing was that among the many recorded teleportation events, only a small part of the ships had managed to sail safely out of the storm at the drop point.

Many more ships, and hundreds or thousands of unlucky people, had become Anomaly 077’s victims.

Even so, the information Lawrence had said that Anomaly 077 itself was not hard to handle. Before the teleportation finished, the freed Anomaly would use its power no matter what. But once the teleportation was over, it was easy to seal again. As soon as a new noose was placed around its neck, it would instantly stop moving. Wrap it up in the shroud and it would fall back into sleep. This mummified corpse had no strength beyond that of a human and was not strong in a fight.

At that point, the White Oak’s crew would only need to deal with a storm. And Lawrence and his sailors had faced countless storms before.

Lawrence bent down and slowly laid his hand on Anomaly 077’s shroud.

The crew on the bridge watched the scene with tense faces.

Lawrence took a deep breath and loosened the knots on the shroud.

A faint sound of someone drawing a breath reached his ears almost at once.

The sound came from within the wrapped mummified corpse.

The shroud loosened as if some invisible force had undone every knot in an instant. Anomaly 077’s true form was revealed to everyone. A mummified corpse lay still on the floor, wearing an Old Era sailor’s smock, with thinning hair and a dried, almost skeletal body.

The corpse’s chest rose and fell slightly, and the motion grew clearer and clearer, until Lawrence felt he could hear its heartbeat and breathing.

Anomaly 077 was free. The Sailor had awakened from its seal.

The mummified corpse slowly opened its eyes. Its whole body sat up bit by bit, stiff and creaking, its joints cracking.

“For now, you have the helm of this ship,” Lawrence said through gritted teeth, his expression complicated. “Get us out of here.”

Anomaly 077 sat up straight and slowly looked around. Its gaze finally settled on Lawrence.

For some reason, Lawrence suddenly felt he could see a hint of fear on that dry, frightening face.

Then he saw the mummified corpse actually shiver.

“Don’t… don’t do this!”

A hoarse, frightened cry came from the mummified corpse. The next second, right in front of everyone, it closed its eyes and lay back down,

pretending to be dead.

It even reached out, tugged at the shroud lying beside it, and seemed to be trying to sneak the cloth back around itself.

Lawrence: “…?”

The sailors: “…?”

Chapter 384: Metamorphosis

Anomaly 077 ranked in the top hundred. It had once caused dozens of ships and thousands of sailors to die in storms. It had a mind of its own and the traits of a living thing. No matter which city-state it was kept in, it was a dangerous Anomaly that the local Church treated with extreme caution – yet now, right in front of Lawrence, it simply chose to shut its eyes and play dead, refusing to use its power at all.

Lawrence had imagined countless possibilities for what might happen after he activated Anomaly 077. He had even come up with several plans to seal “Sailor” again. But he had never thought something like this would happen.

The old captain raised his head and met the eyes of his First Mate. Both of them felt that the mummified corpse in front of them did not match the descriptions in the reports. At the same time, they both wondered where things had gone wrong.

But before they could think it through, the roar of water pillars from the nearby sea and the sound of the White Oak’s defensive guns firing broke their daze.

This was no time to stand there stunned. The Sea Swallow was almost on them.

They could not win in a straight fight, and they could not outrun it. “Sailor”, with its ship teleportation ability, was already the White Oak’s only hope of escaping this danger.

Lawrence lowered his head and stared hard at the mummified corpse that kept its eyes shut and pretended to be dead. Whatever was wrong with this thing, he had to find a way to make it cooperate and enter runaway state.

“Wake up!” Lawrence reached out, grabbed Anomaly 077 by the collar, and shook it hard. Getting this close to a mummified corpse was disgusting, but he could not care about that now. “I know you have already broken free of the seal. Listen, you are taking the helm of this ship now. ‘Sailor’, don’t you have an instinct to control ships? Don’t you have a tendency to enter runaway state on your own? Do it! Take over this ship and get us out of here!”

The mummified corpse on the floor rattled with a creepy cracking sound as its joints rubbed together under the shaking, but it still kept its eyes shut. Its chest rose and fell plainly though, and no one could miss that.

Meanwhile, the non-stop explosions around the White Oak only made Lawrence more and more frustrated. At last he could not stand it. He reached out and slapped the mummified corpse. “I know you are awake!”

The mummified corpse finally could not keep lying there. It opened its eyes in the middle of all that shaking, but its first reaction was still to dodge away. It tried its best to avoid Lawrence’s gaze while it yelled: “Stop it! Stop it! I will go back to sleep, I will go back to sleep, all right?! You cannot joke about this! This ship cannot be touched, cannot be touched!”

Lawrence did not care what it said. The moment he saw the mummy open its eyes, he yanked it to its feet and dragged it toward the helm.

Several nearby seafarers finally reacted too. The bolder ones rushed forward to help. A few people almost had to pin “Sailor’s” dried-up body to the console by force.

The First Mate shouted at their side: “Press it against the wheel! That way its power will take effect the fastest!”

But Anomaly 077 only kept screaming in a shrill voice, and its struggles grew even more fierce: “Let me go! Let me go!

“You cannot do this! Help, help!

“Who even are you people… have mercy, have mercy!”

“Just touch the wheel once!” Lawrence shouted while he used all his strength to press the mummified corpse onto the ship’s wheel. “It will be over soon!”

“I will not! Help!” Anomaly 077’s strength was shockingly great. Even several burly White Oak crew members could not hold its arms down.

It thrashed wildly and twisted its head, trying to look back toward the spot where it had been lying just now. “Let me go back! Please… just loop that rope around my neck again. One loop is enough. I will lie there quietly and sleep. I will never get up again! Or give me the rope and I will hang myself… just do not make me touch this!”

The bridge fell into chaos. The scene was twisted to the extreme.

Anomaly 077, which had a terrifying reputation among captains and sailors all across the Boundless Sea, was struggling and begging like a victim tied up and dragged aboard. The White Oak’s crew members, who were trapped in a desperate situation, looked like fiends as they pinned the “Anomaly’s” arms and tried to press them onto the wheel.

This was a sight that even the maddest patients in an asylum, in their wildest hallucinations, could not have imagined. Yet it was now happening for real on the White Oak.

Lawrence no longer had the mind to think about how wrong all of this was. He only knew the shadow of the Sea Swallow was getting closer and closer. Its gunnery was growing more and more accurate.

The White Oak's broadside had already taken several hits in a row. Fire burned at the stern. If the next shell hit the engine compartment or the magazine, or even the bridge… it would all be over.

As he thought that, a sharp whistling suddenly reached his ears. Judging by the direction of the sound, Lawrence's mind went blank.

[Not good.]

The next second, a deafening explosion swept over the upper deck. A giant fireball rose right beside the bridge and burst open. The Sea Swallow's shell had hit the side of the White Oak's bridge. This hit was fatal.

The blast wave crashed in. Metal and glass were torn to pieces by the shell's power. The torn wall fragments became deadly shrapnel.

A blinding light filled Lawrence's vision. He saw his First Mate lifted into the air, his body swallowed at once by the onrushing wave of fire. Then it was the other sailors on the bridge.

Then it was himself.

The flames swallowed everything. Lawrence watched the fireball swell and engulf the whole bridge. He watched his own body burn away in the flames. Time seemed to slow down.

He saw it all clearly. He even saw the fire creeping inch by inch through the air, and slowly taking on a strange, ghostly green.

Ghostly green?

Lawrence's mind suddenly went blank again. Before he could understand what was happening, the crimson fireball that had rushed into the bridge

turned at once into a sea of eerie green flame.

The sea of spirit form flames licked everything in sight – metal, wood, glass, leather…

Everything the flames burned began to look like a spirit form, turning half transparent.

The crew members who had been swallowed by the fireball all fell to the floor. spirit form flames wrapped around their bodies. Their flesh and bones turned clear and bright like jade. Then, one by one, they got up again as if nothing had happened and stared at one another in shock.

This scene was exactly the same as their first encounter with the Vanished.

It was as if the terrifying sight that had once appeared on the White Oak was playing out again.

A solid feeling under his feet came back. Lawrence jolted awake from his daze and saw that he was already standing at the helm.

At some point, his body had also been covered in roaring spirit form flames.

He reached forward on instinct and grabbed for something. His hand closed around the wheel.

In that instant, he felt it.

He felt everything about the White Oak. From a single screw to a window and a length of rope, every part of the ship appeared in his mind as clearly as if it were a part of his own body.

He had lived on this ship for so many years, but he had never been this closely linked to her.

Along with this feeling, another strong intent flooded his mind. It was as if a voice filled with endless authority was proclaiming his fate.

Now, you are a member of the Vanished Fleet. Go and serve Captain Duncan faithfully.

Lawrence held the wheel in a daze. He sensed the White Oak turning nimbly under the push of his will, and he slowly lined the bow up with the “enemy ship” rushing toward them in the distance.

Anomaly 077 was still there. The mummified corpse had curled into almost a ball beside the console. It shivered as it stared at the rising spirit form flames around it and wailed: “I said I would not touch it, but you forced me to touch it. How would I dare touch it? A Sailor who tries to seize control gets tied to a shell and thrown into the sea! I know the rules on a ship! I am a Sailor!”

Lawrence slowly lowered his head and glanced at “Sailor”. He was still lost and confused and had no idea what had really happened. But his gaze made Anomaly 077 fall quiet at once.

The mummified corpse snapped its mouth shut and carefully stood up. It looked around.

The bridge that had been torn apart by the shell was quickly knitting back together under the burning spirit form flames.

All the crew members stood at their posts. They now looked like ghosts from head to toe, but instinct and the bit of reason they still had drove them back to their stations at once, waiting for the captain’s next order.

“Captain…” Anomaly 077 turned its head and looked into Lawrence’s eyes. “What do you want to do next…”

Lawrence drifted for a moment, then seemed to sense something. He slowly lowered his gaze.

“The Vanished Fleet has been attacked… we strike back.”

“Strike back!” Anomaly 077 shouted at once. “Strike back!”

“Strike back!” The voice of First Mate Gus sounded beside him. Flames rose all over Gus’s body, and crackling fire filled his voice. “The captain has ordered it. Strike back!”

“Strike back!”

The crew on the bridge roared. All across the White Oak, every crew member who had transformed into a ghost “heard” the captain’s command at the same time.

This ship, which had completed a metamorphosis in the flames, moved at once. Its steam core roared. All its guns began to turn. A shrill, howling whistle echoed across the sea.

Under their feet, the ship began to speed toward the Sea Swallow. Almost at the same time, Lawrence saw another shadow at the White Oak’s side.

It was another ship, a warship whose form was almost only a pitch-black outline, shrouded in thick fog and smoke.

Its outline was seven or eight parts similar to that of the White Oak. It was clearly a sister ship of the same class.

That shadowy ship sped up alongside the White Oak. The two ships charged together toward the Sea Swallow.

Through the ever-rising spirit form flames, Lawrence stared in shock at the phantom warship that had suddenly appeared on the nearby sea. He did not know how long he watched before he finally whispered its name, as if in a dream.

“The Black Oak… Martha?”

Chapter 385: The Battle Ended

A shadow wrapped in darkness, a warship that looked as if it had been patched together from smoke, thick fog, and wreckage, sailed side by side with the White Oak. Together, they charged toward the Sea Swallow, which was drawing closer in the distance.

Through the mist that wrapped its hull, one could still faintly see that this ship shared the same origin as the White Oak.

It was not quite the same as in his memory, but Lawrence still recognized it at once. Even though it now looked broken, twisted, and strange, it still tugged at his memories just as it did every time he met it in his dreams.

It was the Black Oak. It was right there, sailing beside the White Oak just like on that last day they left port together in his memory.

A sharp blast of the whistle suddenly sounded and cut off the old captain’s shock and wandering thoughts. The sound came from that phantom ship, as if it was reminding Lawrence that this was no time to daydream.

Shells whistled down from the sky. The Sea Swallow’s bombardment did not let up for a moment.

Lawrence snapped his head back around and saw a fireball slam into the bow of the White Oak.

Flames rose high there, but in the next moment they were swallowed and absorbed by the green blaze that burned all over the ship. A part of the bow was torn into pieces, and burning metal fragments flew in every direction.

Yet in the very next second, the shattered structure began to repair itself, as if time was flowing backward. Under the rising green flames, it returned to how it had been.

Lawrence felt something “drain away”. It was like his strength and life were being shaved off from his “senses”. But that missing part was quickly refilled by the spirit form flames roaring all around.

Right after that, the White Oak’s bow and broadside defensive guns roared. Shell after shell shot out, howling like furious wraiths as they left the barrels. They traced eerie green trails through the air.

Almost at the same time, the Black Oak beside them also began to attack.

As the cannons thundered, flashes burst again and again in the rising black fog. Shells as ghostly as shadows burst from the fog and plunged toward the distant enemy ship.

Lawrence gripped the wheel with both hands and felt the strong tremors that shook the ship with each volley. He felt his senses spreading farther, even flowing along the shells in flight and the seawater churning around the hull, spreading out across the whole sea.

At the edge of his awareness, the Sea Swallow was like a bonfire in the veil of night, shining with a presence so strong it was almost blinding.

Not long ago, that ship had been a hopeless enemy for the White Oak. Yet now Lawrence only felt that this prey looked so fresh… so delicious.

A moment later, the White Oak’s counterattack finally landed squarely on the Sea Swallow for the first time.

With a massive blast and a burst of flame, that strange warship looked as if some invisible giant mouth had taken a bite out of it. A whole chunk was simply “carved away”. In the huge wound that had been eaten out of the hull, the ship’s warped inner structure could be seen clearly.

The attack worked very well, but it was far from enough.

“Full speed,” Lawrence said as he gripped the wheel. His eyes locked on the enemy warship that kept drawing nearer. He already knew what he had to do – or rather, he knew what the White Oak needed right now. “We need to replenish ourselves.”

“Yes, full speed!” First Mate Gus’s voice rang out on the bridge.

The steam core let out an even louder roar. The White Oak, which was already moving at high speed, pushed itself to the limit. It lunged toward the distant Sea Swallow like a swift hunting falcon.

The Black Oak still ran beside them like a reflection, matching their speed and course.

In the distance, the Sea Swallow did not show the slightest sign of changing course or slowing to evade. From the moment it appeared, that ship had launched a blind, wild assault. It was like a runaway state beast without reason.

Even now, after the White Oak had undergone a great change and the situation had turned against it, the Sea Swallow still carried out its first goal with blind loyalty – to attack the enemy.

Two ships rushed toward each other. One was wrapped and shrouded in eerie green flame. The other was covered in twisted, dark, uncanny structures.

They launched a full speed charge at the same time.

The shrill and terrifying howls of their whistles almost tore the sky apart. The growing torrent of cannon fire between the two ships shook the entire sea.

The distance between them shrank fast. Almost every shell they fired slammed into the other ship's hull. Huge explosions tore open their bodies. Burning fragments of steel sprayed across the sea and the sky.

On the White Oak's bridge, Lawrence only stared dead ahead. Everyone else stared in the same direction as he did.

It was as if some force clenched the minds of every sailor on board. Every living being on the ship suddenly lost all fear and all hesitation.

All that was left was a wild hunger for the collision that was coming and could not be stopped.

Then the two ships finally touched.

Like a loose snowball being pressed hard against the red hot wall of a furnace, the Sea Swallow's bow plunged straight into the roaring spirit form flames around the White Oak.

With ear-splitting noise and a roar like ten thousand voices shouting at once, the steel hull that had seemed so solid began to melt away inch by inch in the green flames.

As the "collision" went on, the Sea Swallow vanished into the wall of fire from bow to stern.

It looked as if the whole ship was being swallowed.

Even after the last turret on the Sea Swallow's tail was eaten clean by the spirit form flames, the furious exchange of fire between the two ships did not stop for even a moment.

Then, at last, everything ended.

The White Oak's defensive guns finally stopped their howling. With the enemy gone, the roar of the steam core slowly grew quieter. The spirit form

flames that had been surging all over the ship began to draw in. Their aggressive posture softened.

They settled down to burn quietly along the hull.

For a moment, Lawrence felt lost. At some point his hands had slipped from the wheel. He raised his head and looked around the bridge.

The sailors turned one by one and stared at him. Wrapped in spirit form flames, each of them now looked like a ghost. In their hollow eyes, it seemed there was no longer human reason or human feeling.

Lawrence blinked. Just before the haze in his head could swallow him completely, a human figure suddenly appeared at the edge of his vision.

It was a young man.

He stepped out of thin air, walking through the rising spirit form flames around him. He wore the dark blue robes of the Deep Sea Church priest who served on the ship.

The Holy Emblem on his chest shone like burning fire. He strode straight toward Lawrence, grabbed the blazing Holy Emblem at his breast, and slammed it hard against Lawrence’s chest.

Heat spread out from Lawrence’s chest. He felt his tottering mind suddenly steady. Humanity and reason returned to his soul at the same time.

As the captain came back to himself, the sailors on board also woke up one by one. They stared at each other, as if only now remembering the end of the battle just now, remembering the final clash and “collision” between the White Oak and the Sea Swallow.

Some cried out in panic as the fear caught up to them. Some checked their own bodies on reflex. Others raised their heads and fixed their eyes on the young priest who had suddenly appeared on the bridge.

Lawrence frowned and looked at the man in front of him for a long time before he finally spoke in a hesitant voice: “priest… Jensen?”

“It is me. Thank the heavens you can finally see me,” the young shipboard priest panted, out of breath. He looked as if he had just crawled out of the sea. His robes were soaked through, and water still ran down his hair and along his neck as he spoke. “Praise the Lord of Storms for his protection. I have been shouting in your ear for several days now.”

Lawrence still felt as if his mind was not quite clear. It took him several seconds to recall another strange detail from the past few days.

There was supposed to be a shipboard priest on the ship, just as there was supposed to be a Sun in the sky. But during this whole period, he had never seen this young priest at all.

priest Jensen had vanished not only from everyone’s sight, but even from everyone’s memory.

People had even forgotten the basic fact that “there should be a shipboard priest on the ship”.

Lawrence had noticed that the Sun was gone, but only now did he realize that priest Jensen had disappeared along with it.

“…What happened?”

The old captain, as if waking from a dream, slowly turned his head and asked in a low voice.

“I do not know. For the past few days, it felt like I was cut off in a different dimension from all of you,” the soaking wet young priest said with a bitter smile and a shake of his head. “I could see you, but none of you could see me. It was as if I had become an ‘outsider’ on this ship.

“Not until just now, when the whole ship ‘changed’ in the fire, did I feel that barrier loosen. At the same time, I sensed something wrong with your mind, so I tried to use the Holy Emblem to steady your reason.

“Luckily, I made it in time for that last step…”

Lawrence listened to the priest’s story as messy thoughts and guesses crowded into his mind. When he heard the words “something wrong with your mind”, a late fear finally rose in his heart.

He remembered the strange state he and the other crew members had been in during those last minutes of the fight with the Sea Swallow.

He felt as if a cold sweat was about to seep down his back.

But he had no sweat. He was still wrapped in spirit form flames. This ghost-like body of his had not shown any sign of turning back.

Lawrence lowered his head and looked at his arm, which still appeared in a hazy spirit form state. Many guesses had already formed in his heart.

“The Vanished’s ‘favor’, is it…” The old captain shook his head with a bitter look. For a moment he did not know whether to call this a blessing or the curse. “It seems bearing Duncan Abnomar’s gaze really is no simple matter. But at least we survived… if this really is the state of the living…”

As he spoke, he slowly raised his head again. His gaze passed through the nearby porthole and fell on the sea beside them.

The ship cloaked in thick fog and shadows still floated there in silence, like the White Oak’s shadow.

Chapter 386: Return to the Mortal Realm?

The White Oak stopped on the sea. The Black Oak, shrouded in thick fog like a shadow, stopped with her. In the hazy outline of that second ship, it felt as if a hidden invitation was waiting.

Lawrence looked at the ship and hesitated.

First Mate Gus's voice came from the side and pulled Lawrence out of his thoughts. He asked: "Should we… send someone over to take a look?"

Lawrence turned his head and looked at the First Mate who had followed him through storms for twenty or thirty years. He asked: "…You recognized her too, didn't you?"

"…The last time we saw her was also near Frostholm," the First Mate said. He stared at the sea not far away, his tone complicated. Like Lawrence, he was still wrapped in burning green flames, his body faint and unreal like a Ghost. "All these years, we old subordinates all knew about your situation, but none of us dared to bring this up…"

Lawrence was silent for a moment, then spoke softly: "Do you remember, not long ago, when you saw a figure standing on the deck talking with me?"

The First Mate froze for a second, then reacted at once: "That was…"

"It was Martha—the 'Martha' that only I could see all these years," Lawrence said in a low voice. His words made the First Mate's eyes widen bit by bit. "I have seen her on the ship more than once lately. I even heard

her voice while we were exploring that ‘Dagger Island’… I always thought it was because this eerie sea was amplifying the hallucinations in my mind, but it seems things are not that simple.”

The First Mate slowly turned his head and looked at the Black Oak, which stayed silent and dead under the fog. After a long time he broke the silence: “This is not a hallucination. She is right here.”

Lawrence pressed his lips together and seemed to sink into thought. A few seconds later he suddenly said: “Send a signal. See how she reacts.”

The First Mate nodded at once: “Yes, Captain.”

A moment later, a set of lights along the White Oak’s rail lit up.

The crew members still in Ghost form turned the shutters in front of the searchlights and sent a string of regular flashes toward the black ghost ship that lay so close by.

Lawrence stood on the bridge and stared hard in the direction of the black ghost ship. He waited for the ship to give some kind of response, yet at the same time he almost feared seeing any response at all.

“Martha… are you there…”

The tension made him grab the handrail beside him without thinking. He muttered under his breath as if talking to himself.

The next second, a wavering point of light appeared on the Black Oak’s deck in the thick black fog. It shone for a few seconds, went out, then lit up again, repeating three times.

“…She answered,” the First Mate said. He turned his head and looked at his captain with a complicated expression. “You can wait here first. I will send a few sailors over to take a look.”

“No, I will go myself,” Lawrence said, waving his hand. His face was growing calm; he had clearly made up his mind. “If this really is some phenomenon caused by my mind slipping into a runaway state, then sending other sailors blindly onto that ship will surely be very dangerous… This is something I have to face, and only I can deal with it myself.”

The First Mate clearly still wanted to say more, but in front of a captain who had already decided, he could only swallow his words in the end. He said: “I understand.”

Lawrence nodded lightly: “Then help me get ready. A consecrated lantern, ropes, weapons, ammunition, and also…”

He stopped suddenly and looked toward the helm not far away.

A shriveled mummified corpse in an Old Era seafarer’s coat was there, inching its way to the side with great care. It used the shadows of the helm as cover and tried hard not to draw anyone’s attention. By now it had almost reached the noose hanging beside it.

Lawrence thought for a moment: “I will take it with me. I can’t leave an Anomaly that has already entered a runaway state on the White Oak, and its condition is far too strange.”

Anomaly 077 stopped at once.

…

At the same time, inside the city of Frostholm, at the sewage treatment plant near Cemetery No. 4, the black-clad Guards still watched every intersection with care. Two Warriors stood guard over the unlucky administrator. The man sat limp beside a pipe near the settling pool. His face was pale and his body still shook a little, but he still tried hard to answer every question the Guardians asked.

“I don’t know, I really don’t know… How was I supposed to tell…”

The only ordinary person left on site, the only living human in the whole treatment plant, was the balding middle-aged administrator. He kept wiping the cold sweat from his forehead. Fear and nerves blended on his face. “Everything here was always fine. I have known those people for more than just a day. They never looked strange in any way…”

“Calm down. You are just an ordinary person. It is normal to be fooled by supernatural powers,” said the black-clad Guard in charge of the questioning. The Guard had to comfort the administrator whose courage had been shattered and kept looking up now and then at the open space beside the settling pool. “The Gatekeeper will deal with those freaks—Lady Agatha will be back very soon.”

The administrator looked up at that open space on reflex. At once, the terrible scene from earlier seemed to invade his mind again. The three “church priests” had suddenly turned into strange faces. Horrible Abyssal demons had stepped out of thin air. More than a dozen treatment-plant workers had turned into twisted human-shaped monsters and had thrown themselves into a furious fight with the black-clad Guards…

The unlucky administrator shuddered all over and squeezed his eyes shut. But the darkness behind his eyelids only brought new fear, so he opened them again, his face still full of lingering dread.

The black-clad Guard beside him noticed all this and could only give him a look of pity.

He had lived in this sewage plant, which had already become a nest of freaks, for so long without knowing anything. Around him had been nothing but hidden, vicious cultists and replica freaks that elementses had already used to replace the real workers. When the truth was suddenly laid bare, the fact that he had not gone mad on the spot already spoke of a very strong mind.

Those workers who had turned into replicas were most likely replaced one by one. Now this administrator was clearly the last one left. If the Guardians had not suddenly broken into this place, his fate would likely have been to be replaced as the next “replica” as well. He could clearly imagine that himself, and that kind of after-the-fact fear was hard to put into words.

After this incident ended, this administrator would probably never be able to come back to work at the sewage plant. Forget work; he would likely need long-term therapy before he could return to a normal life. But that was not something the Guardians had to think about.

Right now the Guardians were more worried about their superior. There was no doubt about Gatekeeper Agatha’s strength. Three ordinary Oblivion priests plus a dozen replica freaks that were only good as cannon fodder could not possibly be a match for that Lady. But even so… she still had not returned.

After a while, even the administrator, who was still in a state of fear and panic, noticed how tense the air on site had become. He looked up at the black-clad Guards who stayed on alert all around and, after hesitating for a moment, could not help asking: “Excuse me… is everything alright with the Gatekeeper?”

“Lady Agatha is in the Spirit Realm. She was worried that a battle between supernatural beings would hurt you, an ordinary person, and damage the sewage equipment here,” a female black-clad Guard said in a low voice. Her steady voice carried a calming strength. “Don’t worry. No heretic can defeat the Gatekeeper of Bartok in the Spirit Realm. She is probably just still following the clues, so her return is delayed.”

The administrator nodded quickly: “O-okay…”

The very next second, a cold wind suddenly swept across the plant. The black-clad Guards serving as Wardens at the intersections all turned at the same time to look at the open space near the settling pool.

The female Guardian who had just spoken let out a breath of relief at once and smiled a little: “Ah, it seems Lady Agatha has already taken care of the trouble.”

As soon as the Guardian finished speaking, one phantom after another suddenly appeared over the open ground by the settling pool. It was as if another space was rebuilding its link with the Mortal Realm. Hazy shadows showed up in the air one after another. In just a few breaths, those shadows quickly turned solid and dropped onto the filthy ground.

They were the bodies of more than a dozen replica freaks that had turned into human-shaped mud, and the cold, broken corpses of three Annihilators.

After they hit the ground, the bodies of the replica freaks quickly “melted” into dried mud that would never writhe again. The bodies of the Annihilators began to burn the instant they returned to the Mortal Realm. In a few seconds, black flames turned them into piles of char. The Abyssal demons that had made a symbiotic pact with them did not even have time to regain solid form before they faded away in the air.

The administrator of the sewage plant stared wide-eyed at this scene that went far beyond the Mortal Realm. For a moment he even forgot the fear in his heart. Then he saw a gray-white whirlwind appear in the middle of the open ground. Smoke and thick mist seemed to churn inside it. In the blink of an eye, a figure in a black coat stepped out, condensing out of the Ashen Wind with a Gatekeeper’s cane in hand.

Agatha, who was wrapped in bandages, raised her head. She looked at the familiar Mortal Realm around her and at her subordinates, who all seemed a little tense.

“The problem is solved.” She gave the subordinates a slight nod. Her low, magnetic voice was as calm and reassuring as ever.

Chapter 387: The Sudden Presence

The heretics and misshapen freaks who had been executed in the Spirit Realm had now turned into embers of wreckage in the Mortal Realm. The severe corruption that had hit the sewage treatment plant had been purified for the moment. But when it came to the Shadows hanging over the whole city-state, this was probably only lifting a corner of the Veil.

The black-clad Guards came back to the Gatekeeper. Agatha quickly counted them and confirmed her subordinates' condition, then let her gaze fall on the slightly balding administrator not far away.

"Has his condition been confirmed?"

"It has been checked. He is indeed a normal human," a black-clad Guard said in a low voice. "But he has been badly frightened, and we can't rule out the chance that his mind has suffered corruption. He will need some time for counseling and observation."

"Hand him over to the local Cathedral," Agatha said with a small nod. "Also tell them that the situation at this sewage plant is very bad. The entire facility will need a full purification and inspection later. They can only restart it after all hidden dangers have been checked."

"Yes, Gatekeeper." The subordinate nodded to take the order, then looked up at Agatha with some worry. "You… did not run into trouble, did you?"

Agatha frowned: "Hm? Why do you ask?"

“You stayed over ‘there’ longer than usual,” the subordinate explained. “Did you find some clue when you looked from the Spirit Realm?”

Agatha kept her brows slightly furrowed, a thoughtful look on her face. For some reason she felt as if she had overlooked something. But when she tried to recall it carefully, she could not find anything wrong. Was this a side effect of staying too long in the Spirit Realm?

She shook her head and reached into her coat pocket for the eye drops she used often. But after a moment’s hesitation she put them away again.

Her eyes did not feel uncomfortable at all. It was as if she had already used the drops before returning to the Mortal Realm.

“Nothing happened,” she told her subordinate. “It is just that those heretics showed up in a strange way, so I spent a little more time ‘interrogating’ them.”

It was a pity she had not gotten anything out of them. Those heretics were stubborn and fanatical. Even death alone could not shake their hard hearts.

But… what exactly had she overlooked?

A vague doubt rose once more in Agatha’s heart, but she did not show any of it in front of her subordinates.

“Are we heading back to the Grand Cathedral next?” a black-clad Guard asked beside her.

“Back to the Grand Cathedral,” Agatha said with a nod. “We have to gather people at once and start searching all of the underground facilities in the whole city. The situation may be worse than we thought.”

…

It was close to dusk. The edge of the Sun was slowly nearing the sea horizon. Its splendid twin rune rings spread a majestic glow over the waters.

In the distance, the city-state's buildings were slowly dyed by the sunset. The whole city looked as if it would melt away into the evening glow.

Duncan stood at the narrow window at the end of the second-floor corridor. His broad frame almost blocked all the light that came in from outside. Through the gaps in his bandages, he quietly cast his gaze on the afterglow of the distant sunset, as if lost in thought.

Sneaky footsteps came from the side. Duncan did not turn his head. He already knew who was coming.

"Finished all your homework?" he asked casually.

Shirley had just opened her door and was ready to sneak down to the first-floor kitchen for snacks. She froze at once. In the Shadows beside her, Dog stuck out his shivering head and muttered in a low voice: "I told you we'd get caught…"

"I… I finished the arithmetic sheet," Shirley said. She ignored Dog's hindsight comment and only shrank her neck, looking carefully at Duncan, who stood by the window like a stern iron tower. "I still have to copy the vocabulary once more, but I'm hungry…"

Duncan could hear pure tension and grievance in the girl's voice. It made him turn his head to look at Shirley, half amused and half helpless. He asked: "Did I ever say you are not allowed to eat if you don't finish your homework?"

Shirley shrank her neck again and did not dare answer.

Duncan sighed, turned fully around with a small smile, and pressed a hand on Shirley's head.

"You really don't like studying?" he said helplessly. "You look as if someone has bullied you."

“I… I get sleepy as soon as I look at a book…” Shirley said nervously. She was still not used to talking with Duncan while he was in this body. The bandages and dark clothes looked even scarier to her than the captain on the Vanished usually did. “I… I’ll go back to my room and do my homework!”

Duncan gently pressed down on Shirley’s shoulder, stopping her from turning back to her room.

“If you’re tired, then rest for a while,” Duncan said, shaking his head. “Don’t study out of fear.”

Shirley gave Duncan a look of disbelief, then nodded quickly, as if afraid the captain would change his mind.

After a few more seconds, she looked at Duncan carefully and could not help asking: “Why do you have to make me read and learn characters… I… I don’t have to take university exams like Nina, and I can’t become some scholar like Mr. Morris…”

This was the first time Duncan had heard this question from Shirley’s own mouth, but it was clear that it had been sitting in her mind for a long time. This orphaned girl had never gone to school and had grown up with nothing but a Abyssal Hound for company. It was no wonder she did not understand the captain’s intentions.

“Because knowledge is useful,” Duncan said. He was silent for a while, then looked at Shirley very seriously. “The knowledge that makes you resist it and gives you a headache is what keeps the whole civilized world running. When you look at the cars driving on the streets, the machines roaring in the factories, and the endless sea outside the city-state, have you never felt curious about how those things work? Have you never wondered what faraway city-states look like?”

Shirley thought about it. She seemed to know what the “right answer” should be, but in the end she still shook her head a little hesitantly: “No. I… I always felt that as long as I could fill my stomach, that was enough. I never thought that far.”

“But you now need more than a full stomach, Shirley.” Duncan bent down and looked into her eyes. “You might not understand yet, but I want your life to be a little more complete. You missed many things in the past. Now that you are a member of the Vanished, those things you missed will be made up for.”

Shirley stared at Duncan in a daze. She still did not really understand what the captain was saying, but from his serious and stern tone she seemed to faintly sense a bit of… warmth.

That warmth felt vaguely familiar.

So she nodded, half understanding and half not, and drew out her reply: “Oh…”

“Good,” Duncan said with a smile, slowly straightening up. “Since you understand, go down and eat something later, then keep working on your homework. I…”

He suddenly stopped.

Shirley was still shrinking her neck, waiting for the rest of the lecture. She looked up in slight disappointment: “Ah? What is it?”

Duncan did not answer her. He just waved his hand lightly, but his gaze had already turned far away. It looked as if he was staring at the opposite end of the corridor, yet deep in his eyes it seemed as if a glimmer from somewhere very far away was being reflected.

He blinked. In one eye, the corridor and ceiling of the house were reflected. In the other eye, it was as if he saw a ship burning with dim green flames,

wandering between mist and Shadows.

Out on the sea off Frostholm, in the captain's cabin of the Vanished, which was slowly cruising across the vast ocean, Duncan suddenly lifted his head from the enchanted sea chart on the table.

His sudden movement made Goathead at the edge of the table react at once. The wooden head creaked as it turned its neck: "Ah, Captain, what are your orders? Are you getting ready for dinner? Even though there is no crew available on the ship right now, I am still willing to provide dining services within my ability. What would you like to eat? We can start with southern dishes. Fried meat rolls, fried pork cutlets, fried fish cakes, fried meatballs, roasted bird eggs, steamed bird eggs, boiled bird eggs, stewed bird eggs, pickled bird eggs, smoked bird eggs…"

"Be quiet. I did not look up to hear you recite dishes," Duncan glared at the noisy Goathead, though his expression held a trace of gravity. He raised his head and looked out the cabin window toward the direction of the city-state of Frostholm. He spoke in a thoughtful tone: "The White Oak?"

"The White Oak?" Goathead was stunned for a moment, then suddenly reacted. "Ah, you mean that steamship, the one Alice took before? Why did you suddenly think of it? Do you want to reclaim that trophy? I can provide you with a full set of plans for taking it into the fleet—are you planning to change the sailors on board? That captain should be kept…"

"It is nearby," Duncan said. He did not pay any attention to Goathead's chatter. He slowly stood up from behind the table, speaking as he frowned slightly and felt out a faint but very real link. "Near… Frostholm?"

"The White Oak is near Frostholm?" Goathead finally stopped babbling. His tone was full of shock. "That's impossible… Isn't Frostholm under lockdown right now? And Tyrian's fleet is still blocking the route. If a

foreign ship had come near, there is no way he would not have reported it to you."

"…Something is wrong. I can indeed feel the presence of the White Oak," Duncan said thoughtfully. "But its position is hazy, and it seems to keep changing…"

He narrowed his eyes and looked toward the city-state of Frostholm, trying to pin down where exactly that presence, which had suddenly grown strong in his senses, was located.

The White Oak's presence had appeared all of a sudden and had grown strong in a short time, like a flame that suddenly lit up in the darkness and caught his eye. He had never felt anything like this before.

And, unless it was just his imagination, Duncan also felt that the ship's presence had risen and fallen several times, like a light flickering bright and dim.

As he thought, he lowered his head and looked at the wooden Goathead on the table: "Do you know what is going on?"

Goathead thought for a moment and shook his head: "Why don't I list some dishes for you instead…"

"Useless at the key moment." Duncan twitched the corner of his mouth, stood up, walked around the chart table, and stepped out of the captain's cabin.

Chapter 388: Border of the Phantom Image

After leaving the captain’s cabin, Duncan did not go anywhere else. He simply turned around, took hold of the handle of the door of The Lost Ones again, and pushed it inward.

Zhou Ming returned to his room.

He looked around. The familiar scene entered his eyes. Everything in the room was exactly the same as when he had last left it, yet it felt as if he had not come back here for a very long time.

He slowly crossed the entryway. His feet stepped on the worn, scuffed floorboards. As usual, Zhou Ming went first to the tightly shut window. He checked the marks on the windowsill and then checked the state of the window lock. He knew in his heart that doing this was pointless, yet he still finished every part of the inspection with great care. Then he solemnly picked up the diary hanging beside the window and wrote today’s inspection result in a blank space:

No change at any door or window. During my absence, this room was never opened.

After leaving this new record, he let out a small breath and then slowly walked to the desk.

On the desk, tiny green sparks jumped and crackled. The slowly spreading flame was tracing out the outline of some object bit by bit. The whole

tracing process was already close to its end.

It was a ship. A steam-powered mechanical ship with a beautiful white hull and tall smokestacks that looked quite advanced.

Zhou Ming watched this quietly. His face stayed calm, with no hint of surprise.

The model of the White Oak had appeared in this room. But… why? Why had it suddenly appeared here? What had happened to that ship?

Zhou Ming raised his head and looked at the nearby shelf. The models of the Vanished and Pland still lay quietly in their cubby holes.

Objects that had been completely burned by the fire of the spirit form, and thus completely brought under his control, would appear on the desk of this little studio apartment as precise scale models. This rule was already confirmed. The Vanished and Pland were both like this. But the White Oak…

Zhou Ming recalled the first time he had encountered that ship.

The White Oak had indeed been burned once by his spirit form fire. The entire ship had even been “swallowed” by the Vanished. But maybe back then his control over the spirit form fire had not been skilled enough. After that “burning,” the White Oak had not turned into a “collectible” on his desk. It had only left behind a mark. That state had lasted all the way until now.

Zhou Ming sat down in front of the desk. He quietly watched the ghostly petals of green flame jumping on the desktop as they traced the very last bit of the White Oak’s outline, his expression thoughtful.

He could be sure that during this recent period he had not paid any attention to the movements of the White Oak. He had definitely never taken the initiative to “trigger” the fire mark on that ship. So this change had not

started from his side. It was the White Oak. That ship had clearly run into something, which had activated the mark on it, and even “animated” it so much that the whole ship had now become one of the “collectibles” here.

Zhou Ming narrowed his eyes a little and tried again to locate the position of the White Oak and sense its current state.

A moment later, he opened his eyes. There was a faint heaviness in his expression.

Even here, inside this room, he still could not precisely confirm where the White Oak was. His vague sense only pointed roughly toward the city-state of Frostholm in the world on the other side of the door. And when he tried to confirm the White Oak’s current state, he got a rather strange kind of feedback.

He actually felt that the entire ship was wrapped in seawater.

On the desk, the petals of green flame stopped jumping. The precise model of the White Oak lay quietly in front of Zhou Ming, every tiny detail lifelike.

After hesitating for a moment, Zhou Ming reached out, picked up the model of the White Oak in both hands, and held it up close to study it.

He did not see anything out of place.

After fiddling with it for a while, Zhou Ming shook his head. He realized that he still could not confirm the state of that ship from here. He would still have to go to Frostholm and check the situation there.

He rose from the desk, holding the White Oak in his hands. He planned to put this new “collectible” on the shelf first. But after only a few steps, he suddenly stopped beside a mirror.

He looked at the mirror. In the mirror, what he was holding in his hands was not the White Oak, but a strange warship shrouded in thick black fog and wide swaths of Shadows!

The outline of that ship faintly resembled the White Oak. It looked like a ship of the same design, yet the whole thing had an unreal, phantom-like texture. All over the hull he could see signs of damage and abandonment, as if it had been sleeping on the seafloor for many years. Zhou Ming stared at the ship in the mirror for a moment, then lowered his head. In his own hands, he saw that he was indeed only holding the model of the White Oak.

After a brief spell of shock and thought, Zhou Ming suddenly set the model of the White Oak aside. He quickly walked to the shelf, picked up the models of the Vanished and the city-state of Pland, and tested them one by one in front of the mirror.

There was no change at all in their reflections.

Only the White Oak showed a strange “other form” in the mirror.

Zhou Ming again picked up the model of the White Oak and brought it to the mirror. He watched the dark ship-shadow in the glass, lost in thought.

It looked like the “reflection” of the White Oak in another dimension.

Thinking, he slowly reached out toward the phantom in the mirror.

His fingers only touched the cold, hard surface of the glass.

…

Alone at the oars of the small boat, Lawrence watched as the towering hull of the Black Oak grew larger and larger in his field of vision. The thick fog filled with Shadows slowly closed in around him. The consecrated lantern hanging at the bow struggled to push back the surrounding gloom. It could only sketch out a hazy route ahead for him.

He turned his head and saw that the White Oak had already turned into a blurry phantom in the mist. When he had looked from the bridge of the White Oak, the two ships had seemed so close. But now he felt there was a great gulf between them. That gulf was not a gap of physical distance, but some kind of barrier suspended between the real and the unreal.

And he was now slowly crossing that barrier.

His heart had calmed down. The more eerie it became around him and the darker the surroundings grew, the calmer he felt. It was as if all paths had become clear and fate had shown him every choice. He was going to board the Black Oak, no matter what was waiting for him there.

But it seemed that only he had calmed down. There was another passenger in the boat, and that one did not look calm at all.

“Just let me go back! Put a rope on me, hang me from the mast, anything!” Anomaly 077 chattered. This ugly mummified corpse had been rambling on and on since just now. “As long as you let me go back to sleep, I’ll do whatever you say… Even if you tell me to convert to the Storm Goddess… or the God of Death! I don’t want to keep my eyes open anymore!”

Lawrence finally turned his head. For the first time since they had set out, he answered the mummified corpse: “You can still devote yourself to a deity?”

The mummified corpse froze for a second, then nodded at once: “As long as you let me go back to sleep, I can devote myself to any god you want, even in my dreams!”

Lawrence thought for a moment. A joke that was popular among sailors came to mind, and a smile appeared on his face: “Then you can try devoting yourself to the God of Wisdom.”

Anomaly 077's whole body went stiff. A long time passed before he moved even a little. His shriveled throat squeezed out a few words: "I could start with plane geometry first…"

"You even dare to try the God of Wisdom. Looks like you're really desperate," Lawrence said, shaking his head. He could not help feeling a little curious. "But why are you so afraid? The records I read say you are the kind of anomaly that tends toward a runaway state. But now you're trying everything you can to get back to sleep?"

Anomaly 077 did not answer. He only tried his best to curl up in a corner of the boat and stared nervously at the green flames that were quietly burning on Lawrence's body.

Lawrence lowered his head and looked at his body, which still had not returned to normal. Then he raised his head again: "Is it because of this flame? Or because of the power that this flame stands for?"

Anomaly 077 muttered in a dull voice: "Don't you already know the answer?"

"I didn't expect even an anomaly like you to know the name of the Vanished," Lawrence said, a little moved. "In the records I saw, it said that after you entered a runaway state, you kept your mind and could talk to people. But I didn't think your mind would be this clear… If you weren't a mummified corpse, I would almost think you were a human."

Anomaly 077 lowered his head. He seemed to have accepted his fate and did not say another word.

Lawrence did not pay much attention to this "sailor's" reaction. Right now he had countless riddles to think about. Compared to those riddles, a strange runaway state anomaly whose behavior did not match the records was nothing.

So many unknowns. So many secrets.

How many years had it been since he had last felt this way?

It was as if Adventurer Lawrence had vanished from the world the day he parted from the Black Oak. The unknown and the distant had turned into words from memory, until now.

The moment he saw the Black Oak again, Adventurer Lawrence had woken up once more from deep inside the old captain’s heart.

He raised his head and saw that the towering hull of the Black Oak was now less than a few meters away from the boat. He steered the small boat closer. When he reached the familiar spot from his memories, he stopped and grabbed an oar to bang on the hull.

A rope ladder dropped down from above and landed on the bow of the little boat.

Lawrence turned his head and looked at Anomaly 077, who was huddled in the corner.

“Get aboard, sailor.”

Anomaly 077 got up very unwillingly, head lowered: “Yes, Captain.”

Chapter 389: Stepping Onto the Black Oak

Clinging to the rope ladder, Lawrence climbed up the side of the Black Oak bit by bit. The hull had a dull, dark color, as if it had been scorched by something. At last he reached the deck of the ship.

As soon as his feet touched the deck, he bent over, hands on his knees, and panted several times before his breathing evened out. This made him shake his head with a self-mocking little smile.

He really was old now. He had reached the age where climbing a rope ladder a short way left him needing to stop and rest. In the past…

Another set of footsteps landed behind him. Lawrence put away those stray thoughts and turned to see that Anomaly 077 had climbed up after him. The frightening mummified corpse stood very carefully near the rail and looked quite obedient.

It – or rather, he – had actually cooperated very well all the way here. A terrifying high-level anomaly being this honest was a strange sight indeed. But once Lawrence remembered that this mummified corpse was his only “companion” on this exploration, he gathered up the odd feeling in his heart and made his expression turn serious.

“Did you secure the boat?” He looked at Anomaly 077 and spoke to this special “sailor” the same way he normally spoke to the sailors under his command.

“It’s secured,” the mummified corpse said at once in a hoarse, low voice. Then he raised his head and glanced quickly around them. There was a trace of doubt in his tone. “…It looks like there’s no one on board, Captain.”

“I’m not blind,” Lawrence said calmly as he let his gaze move across the deck.

After they stepped onto the deck of the Black Oak, the eerie thick fog and the texture of Shadows around them were still there, but they did not grow any thicker. Through the drifting mist, he could faintly see the scene on the ship. Everything was just as he remembered. Seven or eight parts of the Black Oak’s layout were almost the same as the White Oak’s. The only difference was that it all had the look of something left to rot for many years. The paint on the railings had peeled and flaked. Parts of the deck were warped and buckled. On the outer walls of the superstructure in the distance, he could even see stains that looked like layers of rust.

If he ignored the strange fog, the whole ship felt like another White Oak – a “version” that had been abandoned and left to drift on the sea for many years without proper upkeep.

And as Anomaly 077 had said, there was no sign of anyone on this ship.

“If there’s no one on board, then who threw down that rope ladder just now?” Anomaly 077 muttered. “And when you ordered them to signal this ship before, it sent back a light signal in reply. Who sent that signal back then?”

“For an ‘anomaly,’ your thinking is actually quite orderly,” Lawrence said, unable to resist glancing back at this “sailor,” clearly surprised. “But don’t you think using ‘logic’ on a ghost ship is a little strange?”

Anomaly 077 shrugged and fell silent.

But Lawrence did not give the mummified corpse a chance to stay quiet. He had not brought this mummified corpse onto the Black Oak just to keep it from causing trouble on the White Oak. He wanted to make some use of it.

“Can your ability work on this ship?” Lawrence stared into Anomaly 077’s eyes. “Can you control this ship?”

“You want me to ‘take it over’?” Anomaly 077 looked a little shocked.

“You are not allowed to ‘take it away’ – but I want you to check whether your ability can work here,” Lawrence said with a very serious face. “Feel it. Find out what state this ship is actually in.”

This “sailor” called Anomaly 077 had an ability whose greatest strength was to control and seize anything that fit the concept of a “ship.” In other words, this anomaly had a sense for and influence over “ships” far beyond human understanding. So… in the eyes of this “sailor,” would the Black Oak show some “special traits”?

Starting from this line of thought, Anomaly 077 might be able to help him uncover the truth here.

The mummified corpse obeyed the order. He stood on the deck and spread his arms, then closed his eyes halfway, as if he were feeling the direction of the wind in the fog. Not far away, Lawrence looked at the familiar parts of the deck with a complicated gaze.

The Black Oak… He was now standing on this ship. How many times had he dreamed of the past and failed to forget the scenes on this deck? How many times had he set sail clutching a stubborn wish to find this ship again? But now, at the very moment he was truly standing here, he could only question everything over and over. He questioned his own judgment. He questioned his own senses. He even questioned the existence of this ship.

The way the Black Oak had appeared was far too suspicious and strange, and the state it now showed was most definitely not normal. Though he did not want to admit it emotionally, reason told him that… this very likely was not the “Black Oak” he had been searching for.

It was only some “phenomenon” created by the supernatural Visions of a runaway state.

Lawrence’s mind was full of tangled thoughts. Only when the “sailor” beside him suddenly opened his eyes and made a confused sound did all those thoughts finally stop.

“What is it?” Lawrence asked at once.

“I… I don’t know how to explain it…” The sailor looked down in shock at the deck under his feet. “Captain, I… I can’t feel this ship’s existence…”

“What do you mean?! You can’t feel this ship’s existence?” Lawrence’s eyes widened at once. He had thought that the sailor’s power might not be strong enough to control this strange ghost ship. He had not expected the other party to give this kind of answer at all. “Then what are we standing on right now?”

“That’s why I don’t know how to explain it…” The sailor seemed startled by Lawrence’s expression, but he still forced himself to go on. “We are standing here. There’s no doubt that it exists. But in my senses, it actually does not exist. At least… at least it is not here…”

Lawrence frowned. He knew that the mummified corpse in front of him had no reason to trick him. This was the other’s true thought at this moment. It was just that… this did nothing to ease the questions in his heart.

After a short silence, he took a breath. One hand lifted the consecrated lantern as he turned his head to look toward a certain part of the deck.

The soft yellow light from the consecrated lantern drifted through the fog, as if it were pointing out an invisible path.

“Captain, where are we going?”

“The bridge,” Lawrence said coolly. “The captain should be on the bridge.”

Before he even finished the sentence, he had already started walking toward the path lit by the lantern. The “sailor” stood stunned for a second, then hurried to catch up, walking with a slight stumble as he asked curiously, “You mean… the captain of this ship? You know the captain of this ship?”

Lawrence’s steps paused for a heartbeat, then he kept walking: “Yes. I know her very well.”

The sailor made a small sound of understanding and then fell quiet again.

A moment later, Lawrence reached the door that led to the bridge.

The red metal door in front of him was slightly ajar, as if it were inviting him in.

“You go open it.”

Lawrence held the consecrated lantern in one hand and drew his revolver from his belt with the other. With a look, he motioned for the mummified corpse beside him to step forward.

“Ah… all right.”

The mummified corpse let out a very human sigh, stepped up to the door, grabbed the handle, and, without seeming to use much strength, pushed the heavy door wide open.

Lawrence leaned forward and looked inside.

The bridge was empty. There was no sign of people anywhere. Only thin mist drifted between the chairs and the control equipment. At the very front,

at the helm, the unattended wheel was swaying gently left and right, as if someone were making small adjustments to their course.

“There’s no one here either,” the mummified corpse muttered beside him.

“I’m not blind,” Lawrence said, then stepped onto the bridge.

He lifted the consecrated lantern and used its light to drive away the darkness around them. His gaze slid past the worn, weathered equipment and seats and slowly came to rest in front of the wheel.

The captain should have been standing here.

But there was no sign of the captain.

Lawrence stood there quietly for a while, then let out a sigh. He himself could not tell whether it was from disappointment or relief. “So, you really aren’t here.”

“No. I am.”

A cool female voice came from the side.

Lawrence jumped so hard even the ghostly green flames on his body flared several inches higher. In the next second, he snapped his head toward the source of the voice.

A young-looking woman in a captain’s uniform stood there, arms folded, her slightly wavy long hair loose down her back. She looked at them with a calm expression that held a hint of helplessness.

“Ah, a woman just popped out,” Anomaly 077 said in shock. Then he seemed to realize something and shot a quick look at Lawrence. “Captain, should I stay quiet?”

Lawrence glanced at the mummified corpse. “Yes. Quiet.”

“Yes, Captain.”

Though Anomaly 077's interruption came at the wrong time, it still eased the stiff, awkward air a little. Lawrence used the chance to steady himself. In his mind, thoughts raced over what he should say first – what should his first sentence be?

In the past, he had spoken with "Martha" countless times. In one hallucination after another, they had already spent many, many years together. But at this very moment, Lawrence suddenly realized he was stuck. He could not act as naturally with Martha as he did when he fell into hallucinations.

And this brief moment of hesitation made him suddenly realize one thing.

The Martha in front of him… was a being acting on her own, completely separate from his subconscious.

Chapter 390: Reunion After a Long Separation

For a long time, Lawrence had felt as if he were trapped in a waking dream. He knew better than anyone what had happened to him, and how his mind had gone wrong.

He knew Martha was no longer in this world. He knew the figure who stayed at his side day and night was only a hallucination. He knew all of it, in his subconscious and in his waking thoughts; he was painfully clear about it.

But compared with other captains of about his age and experience, his mental state was actually quite good. On the vast Boundless Sea, there was never any shortage of captains whose minds had twisted and broken. Even with priests aboard to share the burden, this job that challenged the sea always meant taking on far more spiritual corruption than an ordinary crew member. Every captain finished voyage after voyage by fighting against a mind that kept getting worse. In the end, captains often used one line to describe their work:

“We are not sailing along the edge of the abyss. Our lives are sailing straight into it.”

But it was exactly because of his long years of mental trouble that Lawrence had an especially sharp sense for this “Martha”. Right now, he had already sensed that the figure before him was not the same kind of “thing” as the illusions he had seen before.

He could not help but recall that “Martha” who had appeared earlier on the White Oak’s deck. First Mate Gus had seen that “Martha” too. Had the change started from that moment?

Had everything finally crossed some threshold? Had the things he imagined at last come into the Mortal Realm? Or had some unspeakable power read his mind and created this real “individual” before his eyes? Was this a gift full of malice, or a trap dripping with mockery?

“Martha…” Lawrence finally opened his mouth. His throat felt dry, and even his voice turned hoarse. “You are really in front of me?”

“As you can see,” the woman adventurer laughed. “Want to come and touch me? I even have body heat.”

“…You are a real, solid person.” Lawrence took a slow breath and held back the urge to step forward. “But… why? Did the illusions in my head get transformed into some kind of entity here? Is this… the power of this sea region?”

“At least you got part of it right.” Martha shook her head lightly. “It was indeed this ‘sea’ that shaped me and the Black Oak. But I did not come from the illusions in your head. I have wandered here for many years, Lawrence. For many years, this ship and I have been here as part of a huge group of ‘replicas’, drifting without purpose.”

Lawrence was slightly stunned: “replicas?”

“replicas. Some great power in the Deep Sea caused all this. I do not know what it really is, but it has been entrenched here for many, many years, producing countless replicas. Do you remember the Sea Swallow you just destroyed? And that Dagger Island…”

“They were all ‘replicas’?!” Lawrence’s eyes widened. He suddenly realized the vortex he was caught in was even stranger and more terrible

than he had thought. “Wait, then that city-state of Frostholm we met before…”

“It was one as well. Everything here is,” Martha said calmly. “That power has long soaked this whole sea region. Anything that stays here and drifts long enough cannot escape being ‘copied’. There are countless blind, hollow replicas wandering in the Deep Sea. What you have run into is only a tiny part of them.”

Lawrence seemed frozen. After a long time, he finally snapped out of it and stared at the “wife” before him in disbelief: “But… you look different. You can even talk to me. Just now this ship even fought side by side with the White Oak…”

Martha did not speak. She only watched Lawrence in silence, her eyes calm and meaningful, her gaze resting quietly on him.

Lawrence stopped talking and slowly came back to himself. He lowered his head and looked at his own body, still as unreal and transparent as a Ghost, and at the faint green flame quietly burning on it.

The Black Oak had appeared after the White Oak completed its “molting” in the spirit form flames.

“You have realized it, Lawrence,” Martha said softly. “Only another, even greater power can fight such a mighty force. Even this sea has no right to touch the spoils of the Vanished Fleet. You and I are both the ‘spoils’ of Him.”

Lawrence listened in a daze, feeling a little unreal. Then his expression changed slightly as he realized something wrong about her last few sentences. That was not something the “Martha” who had said goodbye to him decades ago should have known.

Why would she know about the Vanished? Why would she know that the White Oak was Captain Duncan's "spoils"?

"You read my mind!" Lawrence's eyes suddenly widened. His muscles tensed on instinct. "You are not the real Martha!"

Yet the figure standing not far away only smiled, seeming not to care at all about Lawrence's reaction. Her calm was the same as decades ago. She said: "If what you want is a one hundred percent accurate and 'pure' Martha, I am sorry, Lawrence, I truly am not her. But 'she' is a part of me. Martha's soul is inside me. And another part of me comes from your thoughts and memories. This sea is like a mirror. It keeps reflecting everything that passes across its surface. Thoughts and memories are, of course, included.

"I did not read your mind. Your mind naturally reflected and became part of me. Can you not accept that?"

Lawrence opened his mouth. His expression shifted several times. At last he pulled the corners of his mouth in a bitter half smile and spread his hands: "I do not know. I never even thought about how I should react if I really faced you again. I… I do not know how I am supposed to accept you in this… 'form'. I have not even figured out what kind of being you are."

He raised his head. This old captain, who had not flinched before countless strange horrors on the Boundless Sea, now looked a little lost and at a loss for what to do.

He had never shown weakness in front of anyone, except in front of his wife.

Martha quietly looked at Lawrence, who was no longer young. After a long time, she let out a helpless little laugh: "You are still the same as before. At key moments, you always need my help."

She walked over, raised her hands, and set them on Lawrence's shoulders. Her hands had the warmth of a living person.

"You need to steady yourself and keep a clear head…"

Lawrence frowned slightly, a little puzzled.

"Mr. Sailor, could you step outside for a moment?" Martha turned her head toward Anomaly 077, who had been standing there very quietly. "The Master of the Vanished Fleet will be pleased with your cooperation."

The mummified corpse in the sailor's coat gave a start. Without a word, he turned and left the bridge.

Lawrence seemed to suddenly realize something and hurriedly spoke: "Wait…"

But the bridge door had already closed.

Anomaly 077 quickly ran to the corridor outside the door. He only faintly heard Captain Lawrence's last shout from inside:

"Martha – I am already over sixty this year!"

He did not have the heart to listen to what happened after that.

A moment later, the hinges gave a creaking sound. Anomaly 077 hunched his neck and carefully turned his head. He saw the woman adventurer standing at the door with a light, cheerful smile on her face.

Right after her, Lawrence came out too, baring his teeth in pain. When he saw Anomaly 077 at the door, he immediately shot him a warning look, then quickly covered his head and bared his teeth even more.

Anomaly 077 quickly pulled back his gaze and worked hard to lower his presence like a real corpse.

It was clear that he had taken quite a beating.

“Can you accept it now?” Martha turned her head and asked Lawrence with a smile.

Lawrence held the swollen spot on his head. He did not know why, in a form that was almost spirit form, he could still get beaten up by Martha like this. He only knew that such details no longer mattered: “I can accept it. I can accept it…”

When you drifted on the Boundless Sea, you needed to take things easy about everything.

After all, it now seemed that if he could not think things through, Martha would help him “open up” anyway. The woman adventurer’s bold temper was the same as years ago, but he was already a man past fifty now…

“Then next, we should think about serious business,” Martha said with a smile, folding her arms and leaning against the door. “Staying trapped here forever is not a solution.”

Hearing this, Lawrence instantly put away his tangled thoughts, and his face became serious: “Martha, I wanted to ask you this just now. What exactly is the state of this sea? Do you know any way to leave here?”

“…I really want to answer you, but I am sorry.” Martha was silent for two seconds, then spoke with some regret. “I have wandered here for many years, but in the end, this ship and I are only one of the many replicas trapped here. There is one thing I can be sure of, though. This whole sea is centered on that city-state of Frostholm. If there really is a rift here where this place overlaps with the Mortal Realm, it must be in Frostholm.”

Chapter 391: Reflections

Go to Frostholm.

Lawrence instantly thought of the words “Martha” had told him before. By now he could no longer tell whether that Martha back then had been his own hallucination or the trace of presence leaking from this Martha before him. Only one thing was sure: he should go to Frostholm.

But how was he supposed to get there?

“We have been searching here for a long time,” Lawrence could not help but frown as he spoke. “Ever since we left the city’s Harbor under cover of night last time, the White Oak has never found that city-state again. We followed the same route back, and there was only open sea there.”

“You will not find it by searching like this.” Martha smiled and shook her head. “Lawrence, Frostholm is hiding from you.”

“Hiding from me?” Lawrence froze for a moment. “Why?”

Martha did not answer. She simply raised her hand and pointed at the Ghost flames quietly burning on Lawrence’s body.

Lawrence understood at once. He lowered his head to look at his arm, which was like spirit form, and spoke in a thoughtful tone: “So… that was why we were not stopped when we left the city’s Harbor before. It was not that we sailed away from it. It was that the city sailed away from the White Oak?”

He lifted his head, his expression turning a little strange: “Then what are we supposed to do? The White Oak now is even closer to the Vanished than when we left the Harbor. If that city keeps moving away from me on purpose, how can I ever find it?”

“I will go find it,” Martha said, calm and brief.

“You will go?” Lawrence did not react at first. “You can find it?”

“Of course I can. For many years, my ship and I have always been part of this sea region. Even now that I have left this huge swarm, it will not realize it right away. And from another angle, the way the Black Oak exists now is closer to being the ‘reflection’ of the White Oak. I have not built a direct connection with the Vanished, at least not yet. Frostholm will not hide from me. It is not as ‘smart’ as you imagine.”

Lawrence nodded half in understanding, but he still felt puzzled: “But then only you can get close to it. What about me and the White Oak? The moment we show up, it will definitely ‘run away’ again…”

Martha smiled.

She stepped forward half a step and gently pressed her hand against Lawrence’s chest. With a deep, meaningful look on her face, she spoke softly: “It is simple. Let us trade places. Here, the line between body and reflection is not so clear.”

Lawrence stared for a moment and instinctively wanted to ask what she meant. But before he could open his mouth, he felt a slight push on his chest.

The force was very gentle, yet it made him feel as if the world spun. He only felt himself falling backward. In the instant before he lost consciousness, he felt someone support his back, and Martha’s soft voice sounded in his ear:

“Take a little nap, my love. What comes next is an unbelievable journey.”

Lawrence sank into sleep, but he felt as if he had only slept for an instant before his eyes flew open again. He shouted without thinking: “Martha!”

But what came to his ears was First Mate Gus’s voice: “Captain, you are awake?”

Lawrence finally woke up fully. He pushed himself up, panting hard from waking so suddenly, then looked around. He realized he was lying on the bed in the captain’s cabin. First Mate Gus stood nearby with a worried look on his face, and a few sailors were also in the room.

In a farther corner, he saw a familiar figure: Anomaly 077. The mummified corpse was using a noose to measure his own neck when he thought no one was looking. As soon as he noticed Lawrence’s gaze, he instantly hid the rope and pretended nothing had happened.

“What is…” Lawrence caught his breath and muttered while rubbing his forehead. For a moment, he could not tell whether he was still dreaming or back in the Mortal Realm. What had happened earlier rose and fell in his memory like a vision.

“You are already back on the White Oak. ‘Sailor’ brought you back,” First Mate Gus said at once, raising his hand to point at the mummified corpse not far away. “You have been asleep for several hours.”

“I remember… I remember going to explore the Black Oak, and seeing Martha on it… Did those things really happen?” Lawrence rubbed his forehead hard, then lifted his eyes. “Where is the Black Oak? Where is it now?”

“Your memory is fine. You really did go to that ship. ‘Sailor’ also told us that you saw Lady Martha on it.” First Mate Gus reached out to help Lawrence sit up, but halfway through his words, his expression turned a bit

strange. “As for where that ship is now… Captain, things are a little odd. I do not know how to explain it to you…”

“Odd?” Lawrence frowned. “What do you mean?”

“Our ship has lost control. The wheel and the propeller do not respond. The White Oak is drifting like a ghost ship. As for the Black Oak… I will take you to see it.”

Listening to the first mate’s worried words, Lawrence’s expression became serious at once. He pushed away Gus’s supporting hand and stepped after the sailors toward the door.

At the same time, he noticed the changes on himself and on the others.

The spirit form flames that had burned faintly on them had gone out at some unknown time. Everyone’s body had returned to the state of living people. The floor and walls around them no longer looked like they were burning with the same flames as the Vanished. Everything here seemed to have gone back to normal.

First Mate Gus noticed the captain’s gaze and explained: “The flames faded a few hours ago, shortly after you came back.”

Lawrence nodded in silence. The faded Ghost flames were not what he cared about now. He cared more about what had happened to make his usually steady first mate look so hesitant and at a loss.

Soon, he left the cabin with the sailors and came out onto the White Oak’s deck.

In just an instant, he realized how strange the surroundings were.

The air felt damp and cold, as if it had been soaked in seawater. There was no light at all in the sky, only clumps like eerie Shadows floating overhead. There was no wind at his side, yet he felt a cold flow touching every inch of

his skin. From time to time, he saw strange traces of currents nearby, like tiny bubbles rising in the air.

Lawrence felt the wrongness of this environment in shock and dimly realized what had happened. When First Mate Gus led him to the rail, he confirmed his guess even more.

“The Black Oak is there.”

First Mate Gus stood at the rail and pointed at the water directly below as he spoke.

Lawrence lowered his head. He saw the “sea” slowly rise and fall. The ripples raised by the White Oak as it moved spread out with a warped, strange texture. On that sea surface, which looked like a twisted mirror, he saw the “reflection” of the White Oak.

It was a black ship wrapped in thick fog and Shadows. A few lanterns like Wraiths burned on it. It was “reflected” below the White Oak and was cutting through the waves.

In that moment, Lawrence finally understood what Martha’s parting words had meant.

Now, the White Oak was the reflection of the Black Oak.

“Captain…” First Mate Gus watched the change in Lawrence’s expression. His years of following the old captain let him sense that Lawrence might already know what this was. “What is going on? Why has our reflection in the sea turned into the shape of the Black Oak? And the ship’s runaway state…”

“We are not in runaway state. We are just sailing after the Black Oak.” Lawrence breathed out softly, a faint smile on his face. “Let everyone rest and build up their strength. We are heading toward a place that can solve every problem.”

“A place that can solve every problem?” The first mate blinked in confusion. “Where are we going?”

“We are going to Frostholm.”

…

The veil of night was slowly falling over the city-state.

Two figures were moving quickly through the streets, which were already under curfew.

One figure was tall and broad, wearing a long black coat that made people think of the veil of night. The other figure was very short. Even under a thick winter coat, the thin body inside was still easy to see.

A gust of cold wind blew by, and the short, thin figure let out a solid sneeze: “Achoo!”

Duncan lowered his head to look at Shirley, who was rubbing her nose: “I told you to wear a scarf, but you would not. Frostholm at night is much colder than Pland.”

“It is so cold…” Shirley pulled her clothes tighter on instinct. Even though the coat was enough to block the chill, she still felt the wind cutting to the bone. She had been born and raised in Pland, and she clearly was not used to Frostholm’s weather yet. “I kind of regret coming out…”

Duncan looked at the young lady with a half smile: “Were you not the one who said you would do anything as long as you did not have to do homework?”

At these words, Shirley instantly lifted her chin, still talking tough in the cold wind: “Yes, I said that!”

“Every part of you gives in except your mouth.” Duncan sighed helplessly, then lifted his head and looked toward a distant alley. “Come on. I do not

want to deal with the Guardians on patrol."

Shirley hurried to move her short legs to catch up with Duncan. As she struggled forward, she could not hold back her curiosity: "What exactly are we going to do?"

"Confirm someone's condition," Duncan said casually as he walked.

"Someone's condition?" Shirley raised her face to look at the big captain beside her. "Who?"

"Gatekeeper Agatha," Duncan said lightly.

His gaze passed beyond the veil of night, his gaze fixed on the far end of the street.

In his sight, a tiny cluster of ghostly green flame burned, bright and dim in turn, flickering as if hidden behind a thick curtain.

Chapter 392: Inside the mirror world?

In Duncan’s perception, two Marks that had entered an Anomaly state had already drawn his attention.

One mark, of course, came from the White Oak.

That ship, which he had once reduced to ash with his own flames, still gave off a strong sense of existence. It wandered through his perception like a ball of blazing fire. Yet he still could not pin down its true location. Whenever he tried to locate the White Oak, he got only a strange and hazy result, showing that the White Oak lay somewhere near the city-state of Frostholm, in a zone long since sealed off by the Sea Mist Fleet and the Frostholm navy.

The other “problematic” mark was on Gatekeeper Agatha.

Over the past while, Duncan had suddenly discovered that the mark he had left on Agatha had come under some kind of interference. Under that interference, Agatha’s aura grew several times weaker, and her position began to show the same blur and distortion as the White Oak. When he tried to confirm Agatha’s condition from afar, he was startled to find that her aura would sometimes vanish completely from within the city-state.

Two malfunctioning Marks: one on a ship, one on a person. Different locations, similar states.

That clearly deserved attention.

So he chose to investigate the matter in person after nightfall. He still had no leads on the White Oak, but Agatha's mark continued to move now and then within Frostholm, and it should have been somewhere nearby.

Duncan lowered his head and looked at Shirley, who was peering about at his side.

Dog's senses as a Demon from the Abyssal Deep might be useful. And if there really were Annihilators active in the area, Dog would probably pick up the scent of its own kind.

veil of night deepened. The gas lamps along the street were all lit. Now and then a night watchman's whistle or a dog's bark sounded in the distance, mixed with the sound of waves rolling in from far out at sea.

During curfew, the streets were empty and cold. Even the light spilling from building windows along the road could not drive away the chill of this winter night. Duncan led Shirley through yet another narrow alley, and in his "sight" the tiny flame that represented Agatha still paced back and forth not far away.

"Mr. Duncan, if that Gatekeeper sees me… do you think she'll cut me down with one sword stroke?" Shirley said, mostly just trying to find something to say. "Like when Vanna sees a Heretic…"

"Gatekeepers don't use swords," Duncan said casually. "I heard from Vanna that they use specially made combat Gatekeeper's canes and divine magic in the domain of death to deal with Heretics."

Shirley instantly shrank her neck and fell silent.

Duncan did not mind the young lady's reaction. After they entered another alley, he suddenly stopped walking.

Shirley also stopped at once, tense, her face full of alarm as she looked around. "Did you find something? Is that Gatekeeper up ahead?"

“…She isn’t up ahead. She’s right here,” Duncan said calmly as his gaze swept slowly along the alley. “And she has been here for a while.”

“She’s right here?!” Shirley’s eyes went wide. She felt as if another cold draft blew across the back of her neck. She stared hard into the alley, her heart growing more and more uneasy. “Where? Where is she… I can’t see her at all. Dog, do you see her?”

“No,” Dog’s voice came from the nearby shadows, sounding muffled. “I don’t see anyone, and I don’t feel any aura.”

“Even Dog can’t see her?” Duncan’s brow furrowed slightly. Yet in front of his eyes, the tiny flame that represented Agatha burned quietly a few meters away, faint and unreal.

The Gatekeeper was right here. She had been resting here.

Duncan walked slowly toward where the flame burned, then stopped again.

“Agatha” seemed to sense something. When he was halfway there, the little flame suddenly leaped, then quickly moved off in another direction.

Duncan lifted his head and looked toward the direction in which the flame moved in his perception. Suddenly, a flicker of shadow on the glass window set into a nearby exterior wall caught his eye.

On the glass surface he saw a blurred human figure run past in a hurry. In its outline he could faintly make out Agatha’s shape.

Shirley, who had just raised her head to look around, also noticed the shadow. She almost cried out in fright, but she reacted in time and clapped a hand over her mouth. Only after the shadow flashed past did she look at Duncan and speak in a trembling voice: “There was a figure just now!”

“I saw it. It was reflected in the window,” Duncan said in a low voice, his gaze still calmly fixed ahead. In the place Shirley could not see, he still

stared at the tiny flame. It had already passed through the alley, flared once at the junction ahead, then turned and ran in another direction.

He narrowed his eyes a little, as if sketching Agatha's condition in his mind.

She seemed to be breaking out of some predicament. She might have been wounded, or simply exhausted. She had paused here for a brief rest, then headed toward the Upper City. At the junction, something had blocked her path for a moment, but it had not stopped her.

Duncan opened his eyes and let his gaze fall once more on the glass window not far away. Agatha's figure no longer appeared in the smooth pane. It only reflected the faint image of a street lamp in the distance.

"A reflection…" Duncan murmured. "Interesting…"

"Ah?" Shirley still looked completely lost. "What? You already figured it out?"

"Maybe." Duncan gave a noncommittal answer, then stepped up to the window and raised his hand to snap his fingers.

A tiny flame leaped up at his fingertips and lit his figure.

He looked at the glass. In the window he saw the reflection of the flame in his hand. Its dancing light seemed almost alive as it burned quietly in the world of the mirror world.

Shirley watched Duncan's movements in confusion. Then she saw him wave his hand lightly and scatter the flame at his fingertips.

Yet a faint green glow still flickered in her field of vision.

Shirley's mouth slowly fell open as she stared in shock at the scene before her. After Duncan had dispelled the flame in his hand, the spark reflected in the glass window did not fade at all. The reflected fire still burned quietly,

as if it now possessed an existence of its own and was burning inside the mirror.

“Wh-what… what is going on?!” Shirley lifted her hand and pointed at the flame in the glass, stammering as she looked at Duncan. “Why is the flame in there still…”

“A Frostholm of the mirror world,” Duncan turned his head slowly, and there seemed to be a hint of amusement in his tone. “It is gradually merging with the Frostholm of the Mortal Realm. A fine bit of ingenuity. Personally, I find it quite creative.”

“mirror world…” Shirley only half understood, but she still repeated the word without thinking. “You mean there’s another Frostholm inside the mirrors? That ‘Gatekeeper’ ran into the world inside the mirrors?”

“Not exactly, but you can think of it that way,” Duncan said calmly. He turned his gaze back to the mirror, watching the reflected flame that still burned there. “There’s a tiny fissure here, but it isn’t enough.”

“Not enough?” Shirley blinked.

“I need a more precise location and a stronger link,” Duncan said as he slowly reached out and touched the illusory flame in the mirror with his fingertip. “This little spark isn’t enough to ignite the world on the other side of the mirror. However…”

He paused, then drew back his hand.

The phantom flame in the mirror suddenly wavered, then slipped away into the depths of the darkness, leaving behind only a faintly glowing trail of ghostly green that seemed to stretch off into the distance.

“It’s already enough to give Agatha a hand.”

…

How many replicas made from elements had she already destroyed? How many avatar forms of that blond young man had she shattered?

After the count passed four digits, Agatha no longer bothered to keep track.

She only knew that the Heretic had not lied to her about one thing. She really was trapped in this bizarre world, and for now there was no hope of escaping it.

The sky was dim and the clouds churned in confusion. In this “Frostholm city-state” without the light of the Sun, the boundary between day and night had disappeared. Only the subtle changes of light behind the clouds and the gas lamps flickering on along the streets hinted that veil of night had already descended.

Agatha moved through a narrow alley, hurrying along while steadying her breath and mending the wounds on her body and mind.

Her black coat was torn in many places from constant fighting. The soft armor beneath it was badly damaged as well. On her shoulder, along her side, and in other places, the bandages and skin underneath were already visible, with thin traces of blood seeping through.

To be fair, the enemies were not strong. Even the avatar forms used by that blond Heretic did not seem particularly fearsome in the eyes of Agatha the Gatekeeper. It took her only a few minutes to dispatch each one.

But they were endless.

The entire city-state served as their raw material and reserve troops. Ordinary methods of battle had no meaning here at all.

Agatha threaded her way through the alley while her mind worked rapidly.

At the same time, she recalled the strange and terrifying sensation from a few minutes earlier.

She had been taking a brief rest in a dark alley when that dreadful aura suddenly appeared within her senses. The pressure it brought… even made her feel as though her heart had stopped beating for a few seconds.

She had not had time to think then and had hurriedly left her hiding place. But looking back now… that terrifying aura did not quite feel like something that belonged to this eerie replica city-state.

What… exactly had it been?

Chapter 393: Inside and Outside the Mirror

Agatha suddenly stopped walking.

At the end of her field of view, something strange at the mouth of the alley broke off her wandering thoughts.

In that corner shrouded in gloom, one disgusting mass of black matter after another was surging up. They seeped out of the ground and the walls nearby like viscous grease oozing from pipes. Amid slimy, sickening sounds, the mudlike clumps almost instantly began to take on human shapes and turned hostile gazes toward Agatha.

“Truly persistent…”

Agatha let out a soft sigh, but her movements did not hesitate in the slightest. Before the sludge had time to fully congeal, she had already raised her Gatekeeper’s cane and leveled it at the nearest mass.

pale flame flared into being out of nowhere and instantly devoured that writhing lump of elements. The power of Cremation Fire turned it directly to ash. A second later, a gray whirlwind rose in the alley. Ashen Wind howled through the human-shaped replicas that were just starting to climb to their feet, carrying a mighty power of erosion and devouring that reduced them to dry, crumbling dust.

Yet more and more sludge seeped out of the nearby walls and floor. More and more human-shaped freaks appeared at the mouth of the alley, blocking

Agatha’s way.

As Ashen Wind swept past, Agatha’s form condensed out of the gale. There was a bit more weariness on her face. When she sensed a strange new aura suddenly rising from within the sludge, her eyes grew even more grave.

She looked toward the source of the aura and saw a replica formed from elements writhing and mutating at high speed. In a few seconds, it had turned into a smiling young man with short blond hair, a white shirt, and a black vest.

“Miss Gatekeeper, your stamina is truly impressive,” the young man said politely, nodding slightly. “I wonder if you are still enjoying your exercise here?”

“If you think you can tire me to death with this war of attrition, you are being far too naive,” Agatha’s gaze was icy as she fixed her gaze on yet another avatar form of the young man, steadying her breath. “Death means nothing to me. I can still fight after I die. A Gatekeeper’s soul never grows weary, and the day will come when I find you.”

“Of course, of course. Truly killing one of Bartok’s Saints is not so simple,” the young man laughed, his smile bright. “I never planned to kill you. All I need is to keep you here as long as possible. These hollow shells for you to slaughter are just my hospitality, a little entertainment for you when you’re bored.”

“Then you Heretics have a very peculiar way of entertaining your guests,” Agatha knew he was using every trick he could to delay her, but at least for the moment she did not mind saying a few more words while her strength returned. “I’m suddenly a little curious. Is your true body just as relaxed right now? I can feel that I’m gradually closing in on your hiding place. Every monster you control that I destroy makes your position clearer to me. How many places do you have left to hide?”

The blond young man’s smile finally froze for a moment, but only for a moment. Then he beamed again. “Ah, it seems I overlooked something. Bartok’s watchdogs have always had a decent ‘sense of smell’. In that case, why don’t we make a bet?”

He raised a hand as if making an inviting gesture.

“Let’s bet on whether you find my true body first, or Frostholm becomes the first mortal nation to greet the descent of the Holy Lord. The stakes are your soul and the lives of everyone in Frostholm…”

A blast of pale flame erupted with a roar, sweeping over the spot where the young man stood before he could finish speaking. A second later, Agatha had already turned into a howling Ashen Wind. The gale crashed toward the intersection. The gathered replica freaks surged up at once, trying to stop the Ashen Wind, but under the power of the Death Wind they shattered and fell apart. In the blink of an eye, the Ashen Wind slammed into the blond young man wreathed in pale flame and hurled him straight into a low wall on the far side of the street.

With a thunderous crash, the flames were blown apart by the gale, and Agatha’s figure emerged from the Ashen Wind. She held her Gatekeeper’s cane out straight in her right hand. Its tip had pierced the blond young man’s chest and nailed him firmly to the wall.

“Sorry. I don’t gamble,” Agatha fixed her gaze on his eyes, her expression utterly calm. “The clergy forbid gambling.”

“How amusing…” The cultist pinned to the wall by the Gatekeeper’s cane pulled at the corner of his mouth as foul black sludge spilled from his nose and lips. This shell of a body was dying quickly, yet he seemed to feel no fear or pain. “I hope your composure and confidence last a while longer…”

Life flowed out of the shell. The blond young man’s body quickly crumbled and melted into sticky black matter that dripped down and dried almost at once when it hit the ground. The remaining replica freaks he controlled also ceased moving, reverting to lifeless heaps of elements.

Agatha pulled her Gatekeeper’s cane out of the wall and flicked the foul residue from its tip with a touch of disgust. Then she calmly lifted her head and looked toward a certain direction in the Upper City.

She had destroyed yet another avatar form. As its life drained away, the link between the Gatekeeper and the Heretic hiding in the dark strengthened further.

It felt… closer.

“Composure and confidence… I have always believed in myself,”

Agatha muttered to herself. Then she took a few deep breaths, used her Gatekeeper’s cane to steady her body, and slowly walked in the direction her senses pointed. In a puddle behind her, a wisp of ghostly green flame rose from the reflection on the water’s surface, quietly lighting the dim alley.

In the puddles in the alley, in the windows of nearby buildings, on the metal poles of distant street lamps… on every smooth surface, tiny reflections of the flame could be seen.

…

Candles and lamps burned bright inside the Silent Grand Cathedral. The sound of a Gatekeeper’s cane and heels tapping against the floor broke the stillness of the Meditation Hall. A tall figure dressed in black passed through the dark-toned main doors and came to the dais where a black “spirit coffin” rested.

From within the spirit coffin came Bishop Ivan's hoarse, aged voice. "Agatha, you're back. How is the situation in the Second Waterway?"

"The first team only just reached the western entrance. It will take them a whole day just to clear the connecting shaft and send equipment down," Agatha shook her head and spoke with a hint of helplessness. "You have to be a little patient, Bishop Ivan."

"Oh…" The voice in the coffin fell silent for a moment, then asked, "Then what is the state of the western entrance?"

"…"

After a moment, she sighed. "It's an underground facility that has been abandoned for half a century. What else could it be like? I assembled twelve heavy machine guns and three Steam Walkers. Every bullet carries Holy Oil and a flame divine blessing. I also brought one hundred and fifty fully armed Silent Monks. Only then did we drive back the darkness down there. The good news is that we've managed to establish a first foothold at the crossroads beneath the shaft and restore power and lighting to several connecting tunnels. The next stage of exploration might go more smoothly than expected – if we don't run into more cave-ins and gas leaks."

"You found no trace of the Heretics?"

"Not yet," Agatha shook her head. "But the deeper sections are still unclear. The Second Waterway is enormous, and the collapsed zones cut one another off. Right now we've only secured the first passage in one of those sections. There is one thing, though, that's rather troubling…"

A rustle of cloth came from the coffin. Then the dark lid was pushed open from within, and Bishop Ivan, looking much like a mummy, sat up inside.

"Troubling?" The "mummy's" voice was low. "What happened?"

“At the ends of some of the old pipes, we found signs that someone had repaired and modified them. There were also some suspicious branch conduits stretching off into the dark,” Agatha said with a frown. “We checked the original blueprints in the archive and confirmed that those pipes weren’t in the designs from back then.”

Bishop Ivan was silent for a while, then asked in return, “…What do you think?”

“It looks as if someone continued to maintain the Second Waterway after it was abandoned and made certain alterations,” Agatha said, voicing her thoughts. “The maintenance wasn’t continuous, so many areas were still left to decay after a few years. But deeper in the sewers, there may be things that are still operating.”

Bishop Ivan listened quietly. After a long time, he finally spoke slowly. “The Second Waterway… it’s a vast underground kingdom, large enough to hold countless secrets. Even if you poured every Guardian unit you have into it, you still wouldn’t fill all of its corridors and junctions. So don’t focus too much on those minor traces of modification. Concentrate on hunting the Heretics. Leave everything else for the people at City Hall to worry about.”

Agatha glanced at Bishop Ivan, then nodded thoughtfully.

Bishop Ivan, however, noticed the weariness in the Gatekeeper’s expression. “You look like you haven’t rested. An exploration of this level shouldn’t have left you so exhausted. Are you unwell? Ever since you came in, you’ve seemed preoccupied.”

Agatha parted her lips, hesitated for a few seconds, then spoke. “A little… unsettled.”

Chapter 394: Encounter in the Fog

“Uneasy?” After he heard Agatha’s reply, Bishop Ivan’s tone changed. He stared at Agatha and said: “For a Saint, feeling ill at ease is not a good sign… What happened? When did it start?”

“Right after we came back from that sewage treatment center that was struck by corruption,” Agatha did not hide anything. She knew the old Bishop in front of her was the person she trusted most in the whole city-state. “I keep feeling that I forgot something, as if… I left something there. But I have gone over everything that happened there many times, and I did not find anything wrong.”

“That sewage treatment center…” Bishop Ivan’s voice was low. He of course knew what Agatha was talking about. They had reported that matter at once to the Cathedral and City Hall, and the later investigation and purification work was still going on in full. “I have been watching that case too. The one surviving manager is still in the asylum receiving treatment. The dozen or so original workers of the plant are still missing. And from the sampling reports on site, you should have already Purified all the corruption in the entire facility at that time. In theory, there should be no hidden danger left.”

“But I still feel uneasy,” Agatha admitted. “Even though there is no proof, I am sure I have overlooked something.”

“…Have you checked your own mental state? What were the results of your Cognitive Calibration?”

“Of course I checked,” Agatha nodded. “I did both self Cognitive Calibration and a subconscious check with a psychiatrist’s help. Nothing was wrong.”

Bishop Ivan did not speak for a moment. After a few seconds, he broke the silence with a thoughtful tone: “Then it may be that something inside you is sounding a warning. It may be from your subconscious, it may be from your Spirit Sight, it may even come from your faith.”

“I will go back there and check again,” Agatha nodded. “Before that, I want to go to the prayer room and pray for a while. I hope the Lord can give me some guidance.”

Bishop Ivan gave a slight nod: “Go. I hope prayer can ease your troubles.”

Agatha made a small sound of assent, stood up, and left the platform where the spirit coffin was parked. A moment later, she disappeared beyond the doors of the Meditation Chapel.

The broad chapel fell quiet. Only Bishop Ivan, who looked almost like a mummy, still sat on the edge of the spirit coffin. He watched the direction where Agatha had left, as if lost in thought. After a long time, he finally sighed softly and raised his hand to trace the God of Death Bartok’s Triangular Sigil over his chest: “May the Lord guide us…”

In the silent Meditation Chapel, the candelabras set into the wall niches burned quietly. The flames trembled without a sound, and the smooth black marble floor, polished like a mirror, reflected the light from each stand. Around those flickering flames, it seemed as if many vague phantoms flashed by and vanished.

…

Outside Frostholm, along the border of the Nearshore Waters, a patrol ship flying the Frostholm navy flag was sailing along the prescribed route,

patrolling the sea.

A navy commander stepped onto the foredeck and frowned as he looked out at the distant sea. The cold light of the World's Wound poured down from the sky, giving the rippling waves a pale sheen. Between those glints of light, he could sometimes see chunks of floating ice of different sizes. Far away, those chunks drifted in a neat, single direction, faintly forming an invisible "border line".

The commander of course knew what those seemingly natural "floes" really were. They were not chunks of ice at all, but part of the Sea Mist Fleet.

That was the floating ice around the Sea Mist. Whenever that ghost ship under the curse appeared on the sea, such ice would appear around it. They marked that pirate captain's sphere of influence and were also a sign of the power of the curse tied to the Sea Mist. Any ship that dared to approach the Sea Mist without permission would first receive the "baptism" of those floes. In the mild case, its movement would be blocked. In the serious case, it would be frozen solid on the sea, and everyone on board would turn into Restless Souls in the ice.

The Sea Mist often used this method to block sea lanes, stopping merchant ships that passed through its waters and charging them so-called "ice clearing fees". In most cases, that ship did not even need to fire a single shot to finish this shameful extortion.

Of course, for now the Sea Mist Fleet had temporarily lifted its state of hostility with the Frostholm navy. Those floes would not actively spread toward the navy's patrol ships. But their very presence was a kind of warning. The meaning they sent was clear:

Even though this was Frostholm's own doorstep, everything beyond this line was still the Sea Mist Fleet's territory.

The commander in his Frostholm navy uniform gritted his teeth and let out a sigh, trying hard to calm his mood.

The bigger picture mattered most. A soldier should obey his superiors' judgment. The city-state needed safety, and that safety now needed the Sea Mist Fleet.

The lockdown of the whole sea area was above everything else.

"The sea is getting foggy again," a junior officer came up onto the deck and muttered as he looked into the distance. "It's almost foggy every day now."

The patrol ship's commander lifted his head and looked at the sea ahead.

Just as his subordinate said, mist was rising over the sea. The fog, as thin as gauze and as thick as a curtain, was slowly gathering on the surface and spreading around that "ice border". The light of the World's Wound filled the mist and made the area look deathly pale.

"Most likely the Sea Mist is doing this again," the commander said with a frown. "Wherever that ship goes, the floating ice and fog follow."

"The Sea Mist has not moved from its position," the subordinate said. "Maybe that 'Pirate General' just wants to show he is still there?"

"No matter what he thinks," the commander shook his head. "We must not go near the fog or the ice. Frostholm cannot be the first to break the agreement."

"Yes, sir."

The commander made a brief sound in reply, then looked again at the distant layer of fog. A hint of doubt came to his face: "But then again… is the fog a bit thicker than usual tonight?"

The subordinate followed the commander's gaze. The fog spreading around the floating ice really was still growing, and it looked denser than on past

days. Deep within the thickening mist, there seemed to be something faintly swaying.

“The fog really is getting thicker…” the junior officer muttered. “Is there something in the fog?”

“…Something is wrong.”

The patrol ship’s commander spoke, then his expression suddenly changed. He quickly grabbed his binoculars and looked toward the thickest part of the fog. After a moment of careful checking, he finally confirmed that something really was moving inside that dense mist. It was very large and was coming closer.

It was a ship!

“It’s a ship, coming from inside the Sea Mist Fleet’s patrol area,” the commander lowered the binoculars and said quickly. “Signal them with lights. The Sea Mist Fleet is crossing the boundary. Tell them to stop at once.”

“Yes, sir!”

The junior officer answered loudly and ran quickly toward the rear of the deck. Before long, the large searchlight mounted on the upper level of the patrol ship lit up and sent a series of light signals toward the thick fog.

However, the warship’s shadow moving inside the dense fog showed no sign of slowing down.

The patrol ship’s commander stared hard at the blurry shadow in the fog. He saw that the other ship was not slowing at all. It was speeding up and charging straight at them. As it came closer, the fog over the surrounding sea also seemed to spread on purpose. In just a short time, the rolling mist had already spread to within a hundred meters of the patrol ship and even started to close in from all sides.

“Damn pirates!”

The patrol ship’s commander could not help cursing under his breath. He turned and ran quickly to the bridge. As he rushed to the control station, he shouted: “Engines astern, turn the ship! That thing is heading straight for us. Any reply from the Sea Mist Fleet?”

“No response to the light signals! No answer to short-range calls either!” A soldier at the nearby console shouted back. “We’re calling the Sea Mist on the agreed frequency, but there’s still no reply from their side… wait, we have a response!”

The communication light on the console suddenly lit up. The automatic recorder started to clatter, and a long strip of punched paper tape slid out of the machine. The signalman grabbed the tape and quickly read the marks on it. A moment later, he looked up in confusion: “The Sea Mist Fleet says they did not cross the boundary. All their ships are still in place.”

“All still in place?”

The patrol ship’s commander stared, then suddenly raised his head and looked out the porthole. The thick fog had already reached the bow of the patrol ship. Even though the helmsman was trying hard to turn, the ship still could not move faster than the spreading, eerie mist. Inside the fog rolling toward them, that hazy shadow was drawing closer and closer.

“Turn! Hard to port, turn!”

The patrol ship tilted hard. The steam core let out a hoarse roar. The rudder and the side thrusters worked together with a force that seemed strong enough to tear the whole ship apart as they tried to swing it around in the fog. In the middle of the violent shaking and the many harsh noises, the patrol ship’s commander held tight to the rail beside him and stared wide-eyed at the sight beyond the porthole—

Out of the suddenly torn-open mist, a huge ship burst forth, almost brushing against the patrol ship’s rail.

It was not part of the Frostholm navy, nor was it a member of the Sea Mist. It was a mottled, rust-covered Old Era warship. The badly damaged paint on its hull and the outdated design of its bow seemed to silently tell of the long years it had gone through.

The patrol ship’s commander stared in shock as the huge vessel brushed past his own ship. It took him several seconds to react. Then he suddenly remembered an illustration and record he had once seen in an old file—

“It’s the Valiant… the warship that sank forty years ago…”

Chapter 395: The Approaching mirror world

On the patrol ship, everyone stared in shock at the huge vessel that had suddenly rushed out of the dense fog. They watched its bow, nearly twice as tall as the patrol ship, slide past almost scraping the rail. They watched its mottled, rusted hull move slowly forward. Above the Valiant there still seemed to hang old, ragged flags. Those strips of cloth, their original patterns long gone, flapped wildly in the night wind and looked like a loosened… shroud.

The patrol ship's commander was the first to react.

"Keep turning, speed up and move away!" he shouted. "Don't let us get caught in that ship's wake!"

Passing this close to a main battleship was extremely dangerous, especially for a small vessel like a patrol ship. The water around and behind a large ship could badly disturb a smaller ship's course. In the violent rolling, any scrape could be fatal.

The steam core began to roar again. By now the helmsman could already feel the terrible effect of the great ship. The patrol ship's hull was drifting and rolling to one side. He had to use all his strength to hold the ship steady in the chaotic currents and to speed away from the huge mass so close by.

The helmsman's efforts were close to failing.

The Valiant’s speed was faster than expected, and the chaotic currents swirling around it were even stranger, beyond anything the helmsman had seen in all his years of experience. He felt as if countless invisible ropes had wrapped around the patrol boat’s rudder and keel down on the seafloor, maliciously dragging the little vessel toward that old warship that looked like a ghost ship.

The whole ship began to creak and groan in a disturbing way, as if something unseen were trying hard to tear it apart.

The tiny gap the patrol ship had won at the start by its sudden turn and full engines lasted only a few breaths. Then the whole ship began to slide toward the Valiant’s stern at a speed the naked eye could see. That rusted “cliff” grew quickly larger in everyone’s view. Many wavering, half-human, half-not shapes appeared near the Valiant’s rail and looked down at the small ship about to capsize with a gaze that made one shiver.

“We’re going to hit! We’re going to hit!”

Someone cried out. The seamen ran at once to the nearest railings or handholds to keep from being thrown overboard at the moment of impact. But at the very instant the side of the patrol ship touched the Valiant’s stern —the latter vanished.

The Valiant was gone. It vanished before all their eyes.

Like a nightmare from which they had been shocked awake, the old main warship that had blotted out the sky a second ago simply vanished in an instant before the soldiers’ eyes. It left only a terrible image and a shaking fear in every heart. On the bridge and on the deck, people looked at one another as if they had just woken from a long dream, not sure where they were.

The fog thinned and faded. The cold light of the World's Wound spilled over the sea. The icy sea wind cleared many minds. On the empty surface, only choppy waves remained, along with drifting fragments of ice far away.

The patrol ship's commander slowly let go of the rail he had been gripping and walked to the porthole to look at the sea outside. A subordinate came to stand beside him and muttered as if talking to himself: "A group hallucination? Was that just an illusion?"

"…It was not a hallucination," the commander said in a low voice. He raised his hand and pointed at a section of rail outside the porthole. "See that? The rail is damaged. We did hit it just now."

"Then where did it go? The Sea Swallow before was not like this… the Sea Swallow never 'vanished into thin air' like that, not until it was completely blown apart. And just now the currents around us suddenly changed. The helmsman could not even control our course…"

The commander did not answer at once. After thinking for a long time, he finally said slowly: "Maybe… we just sailed into some kind of gap. The one that suddenly appeared and suddenly disappeared was not that ghost ship, but us."

Shock and fear flashed across the subordinate's face. He then looked instinctively toward the distant sea and the direction of the city-state of Frostholm. After a few seconds he spoke: "Then… have we now returned to the Mortal Realm?"

"…Call both the Sea Mist and Frostholm Island at the same time," the commander said quickly after a short pause. "Compare their replies and judge our own situation from that. Before we are sure, do not go near any ship that appears in these waters."

"Yes, sir."

…

“They ran into a warship that sank forty years ago? And that warship suddenly vanished just before it hit them?” In the captain’s cabin of the Sea Mist, Tyrian leaned back in his chair and raised his brows after hearing First Mate Aiden’s report. “Now they are still circling in their patrol area, because they are not sure whether they have really returned to the Mortal Realm?”

“Yes. From the signs during their encounter with the Valiant, that patrol ship’s commander seems to think they briefly sailed into an Anomaly sea area. Now they are contacting both the Sea Mist Fleet and Frostholm at the same time to try to use the answers to judge whether the environment around them is real,” Aiden nodded, then shrugged. “I think they might be a bit terrified and jumpy.”

“…No, that is the right kind of caution,” Tyrian shook his head, his face quite serious. “We may not like the Frostholm navy as it is now, but we have to admit that they have truly guarded the city-state for fifty years. In experience with fighting supernatural Visions, they are no worse than we are. That commander’s judgment is probably correct.”

Hearing the captain’s words, Aiden’s face also grew serious at last: “So… they really did briefly sail into an Anomaly sea area that might overlap with the Mortal Realm? And they met the Valiant there?”

“The Valiant… I still remember that ship. When it was first built, the Queen herself came to cut the ribbon for it,” Tyrian said with some feeling. “Do you remember how it sank?”

“Of course I remember. We were the ones who sank it,” First Mate Aiden nodded. “After rebels took control of that ship, they rebuilt it and then sent it to wipe out our ‘defector fleet’. In the very first battle, it was sunk by the

ambush you set up off the coast of Frostholm. Several rounds of shelling hit its magazine and fuel stores in turn. It was almost broken in half."

"Yes, broken in half. But the Valiant that patrol ship saw was a whole, intact ship," Tyrian said. "So it is clear. It is a replica, like the Sea Swallow."

"Frostholm has been trying to find where those replicas come from, because they always seem to 'appear out of thin air'…" Aiden said in thought. "Could it be… a hidden overlapping space?"

"Frostholm will get the news soon enough. Their smart ones will work out that possibility. As for us, we do not need to worry for them. We have our own task."

"Are you going to report this to the old captain?"

"Of course. He has been waiting for my new report," Tyrian said. He raised his hand and pointed toward the door. "Go out first and close the door. Do not let anyone else come in."

"Yes, Captain."

…

"Tyrian has reported something new."

In the city-state of Frostholm, inside a temporary residence on Oak Street, Duncan spoke to Morris and Vanna, who sat across from him.

Beside him, Nina was happily reading a history book. Shirley, who had followed Duncan around outside until midnight, was already so sleepy that she was almost falling off her chair.

"Something new?" Morris quickly adjusted his sitting posture. "Did something happen at sea?"

“A Frostholm patrol ship in the southwest waters met a navy warship that sank forty years ago. It seems to be a replica like the Sea Swallow. But the two sides did not fight. After a light collision, that replica warship vanished into thin air right before the patrol ship’s eyes. Right now it is hard to say whether a new replica has suddenly appeared on the sea, or whether that patrol ship briefly sailed into an Anomaly sea area that runs parallel to the Mortal Realm. The second possibility is more likely.”

“…An Anomaly sea area parallel to the Mortal Realm…” Morris weighed this line and his expression slowly grew grave. He looked up. “This seems to confirm what you found tonight…”

“Yes. There is another Frostholm in the mirror. If all the replicas, and even the cultists’ lairs, are hidden inside a ‘mirror world’, that would explain why we could search the whole city and still never find the source of the corruption,” Duncan said slowly. “And Crow, who once vanished without a trace and then returned out of nowhere, the many replicants in the city whose origins are unknown, certain people’s disappearances… all of that can be explained.”

Morris and Vanna looked at each other. In each other’s eyes, they saw the same heavy mood.

“…Ordinary heretics and demons I can handle. No matter how strong the enemy is, if we gather enough people and firepower, we can always wipe them out. But enemies inside the mirror…” Vanna frowned tightly and looked troubled. “I cannot think of a way to deal with them right now. I cannot even figure out how those heretics did it.”

“If this is also part of the Abyssal Lord’s divine authority, then His power has clearly not only spread from the Deep Sea to the surface, but is now spreading on a large scale. This is no longer just the ‘small trouble’ of making a few replicas,” Morris said as well.

The two “professionals” both seemed stuck in their worries. Seeing this, Duncan smiled: “In fact, I have already cast a Fire Seed into the other side of the mirror.”

Morris and Vanna: “…What?”

Chapter 396: Alice of Unknown Material

Duncan had indeed already cast a Fire Seed into the Frostholm city-state inside that mirror world, but he felt it was still far from enough.

He could clearly feel that Frostholm was different from Pland this time. The Fire Seed he had thrown did not spread quickly on the “other side of the mirror”, and his sense of the Fire Seed was faint and disturbed. He guessed this might be because there was a natural barrier between the worlds on the two sides of the mirror, or because the mirror world and the Mortal Realm did not actually match up exactly. The parts that were out of alignment were interfering with his judgment.

Whatever the reason, he needed to find a way to strengthen his link with the Fire Seed, and to strengthen his connection with the White Oak and with Agatha.

While they were talking, Vanna suddenly showed a thoughtful look and said: “Speaking of the mirror world… you are sure you saw the Gatekeeper’s figure in the glass reflection, yes?”

“Of course I am sure.”

“Then that is rather strange…” Vanna frowned. “If she really is trapped in that mirror world world, how is it that the city-state has not shown the slightest sign of it? The High Protector has vanished under odd circumstances. Even if they sealed the news to keep people calm, at the

very least the Cathedral and City Hall should be taking some other action…”

She paused, then summed up from her own experience: “Secret searches, a limited lockdown in certain areas, changes in the frequency and pattern of Guardian patrols at night. Even if the news is blocked, details like that can still be observed. But today Mr. Morris and I moved around the city-state for a long time, and we did not see any such changes.”

Nina, who had been reading with her head down, suddenly looked up: “Maybe it’s because the Gatekeeper has only just gone missing. The city-state might not have reacted yet.”

“If that really is the case, then Frostholm is rotten beyond saving,” Vanna said, shaking her head very seriously. “But from what I’ve observed these days, even though this city-state is in a certain state of decline, it’s not that bad in other respects. At least the Church and City Hall still operate in an orderly way.”

“Maybe by tomorrow, during the day, we’ll see a change in the city’s mood,” Duncan said casually. Just as he was about to go on, a heavy weight suddenly pressed down on his arm, cutting him off.

Shirley had slumped over and bumped her head into his arm, and was now snoring evenly.

But the next second, before Duncan could react, he saw the young lady jerk awake straight out of her sleep. Dog, who had been dozing at the foot of the sofa, was flung straight into the air with her movement: “S-s-sor… so… so __”

Shirley never even managed to stammer out the word “sorry” in full. Duncan heard a loud thump as Dog, who had been thrown into the air,

landed on the floor. Dog rolled over in one motion and sprang back up, his head buzzing: “What’s going on, what’s going on, are we fighting?”

Then he noticed that the atmosphere around them felt strange. He looked up and saw several pairs of eyes resting on him and Shirley in a very odd way.

“We’re not fighting. Shirley just fell asleep,” Duncan said with a helpless laugh, looking at Shirley, whose whole body was still tense. “It’s fine. Go upstairs and sleep. Minors need enough rest. Nina, you stop reading too. It’s bedtime.”

“Oh.” Nina reluctantly closed the book she was halfway through, stood up, and took the still-nervous Shirley by the hand. The two girls walked hand in hand toward the second floor.

Duncan watched the two girls disappear up the stairs, then turned his gaze back and nodded to Vanna: “Tomorrow you and Morris go to the Upper City and see whether there’s any change in the mood around the Cathedral. If possible, feel out City Hall’s reaction as well. With things having developed to this point, Frostholm’s City Hall has stayed strangely low-key. I’m very curious what they’re actually doing.”

“Alright,” Vanna nodded, then asked with some curiosity: “What about you? What are you planning to do next?”

“I plan to visit the Second Waterway again, together with Alice,” Duncan said offhandedly. “We’ll go look at the corridor where Crow had that incident. Now that we suspect there is a ‘mirror world Frostholm’, and Crow very likely strayed into it back then, we might be able to find some new clues in that corridor.”

As he spoke, something suddenly occurred to him: “Speaking of which, is Alice still in the kitchen cleaning up?”

“Seems like it,” Morris said as he got up and turned to look. “She really has been held up in the kitchen for a long time… her head hasn’t fallen off and gotten stuck in some corner, has it?”

“She never lets people relax… I’ll go check,” Duncan sighed helplessly, then rose from the sofa and headed for the kitchen.

As soon as he reached the kitchen, he saw the gothic doll standing beside the sink. She had not lost her head like Morris had guessed, but she had tilted it back at a strange angle and was staring blankly at one corner of the ceiling.

Alice was so focused that she did not hear Duncan’s footsteps. She only stared dumbly at that empty spot, then reached out with the hand holding the kitchen knife and poked at the air. After that she changed direction and kept poking at the air—like she was trying to catch an invisible fly.

A gothic doll stood in the kitchen with a vacant look, raising a kitchen knife and slicing at the air. The scene was far too eerie, as if at any second a health bar filling the entire screen would pop up over the doll’s head, and an organ-style background music would start playing around them. Duncan finally could not help speaking: “What are you doing?”

“Wah!”

Alice jumped in fright. She instinctively reached up to steady her head—but she forgot she still had a sharp knife in her hand. The next second, there was a soft stab, and she drove the blade straight into her own forehead.

With a sharp crack, her entire head was knocked off by herself.

Even though Duncan had seen this doll’s creepy and unreliable antics many times, he was still stunned. He quickly stepped forward to steady Alice’s swaying body. Then he saw her arms flailing in a panic—the sharp kitchen knife was still in her hand, and its tip was skewering her own head. She

waved it several times like that before finally realizing what was going on. Then she hurriedly hugged her head with her left arm and, with her right hand, yanked the knife out of her forehead.

The doll then groped around and tossed the knife aside. With practiced ease, she picked up her head, pressed it back onto her neck, and with a soft pop, everything returned to where it belonged.

“You gave me a fright!” Alice turned her head and looked at Duncan with a slightly wronged expression. But very soon her eyes were drawn to something on Duncan’s arm. “…Captain, this knife looks kind of familiar.”

Duncan’s face stayed expressionless behind his bandages as he grabbed the handle of the kitchen knife stuck in his arm, pulled it out, and casually tossed it aside: “Of course it does. You just stabbed it into me.”

“…I’m sorry!” the doll cried out at once. She rushed over in a fluster to check on him. “Are you alright? Do you need to be bandaged?”

“No need. It’s a corpse anyway.” Duncan’s mouth twitched, but his gaze was drawn to Alice’s forehead.

A moment ago, the doll’s forehead had been split open by her own stab, leaving a great wound there. But now that wound was healing at a speed visible to the naked eye. There was no blood in the cut, only a smooth, jade-like surface, and after just a few breaths it was completely restored.

Alice felt a little awkward under Duncan’s gaze and subconsciously touched her face: “Why are you staring at me…”

“What exactly are you made of?” Duncan frowned and touched the place where Alice had been wounded. What he felt was similar to skin, but cold and without any sense of life. “You just had a hole in your head, you know?”

Alice froze for a moment, then raised a hand to touch her forehead. She answered in a dazed tone: “It healed.”

“I know it healed!”

“…I don’t understand,” Alice shook her head. “I don’t know what material I’m made from either… but it doesn’t seem like wood or ceramic…”

Duncan held it in for two seconds, then tugged at the corner of his mouth. “I really shouldn’t expect any answers from you. Forget it, let’s not talk about that. What were you doing just now? Why were you staring at the ceiling?”

“Threads,” Alice answered honestly. “Some threads suddenly appeared just now. But now they suddenly disappeared again.”

Duncan’s expression changed at once: “Threads?!”

Alice could see special “threads”, and those threads represented people.

“Yes,” Alice nodded seriously. “I was curious why threads suddenly appeared, when there’s nobody else here… But I remembered what you taught me, that I mustn’t grab other people’s ‘threads’ at will. So just now I used the kitchen knife to poke them instead…”

Duncan did not care what the doll had said in the second half of that sentence. His attention was already all on those “threads” that had suddenly appeared and then vanished.

His eyes swept quickly across the kitchen. He looked for anything here that might be used to build a connection to the mirror world.

The glass in the window. The water pooled in the sink. The surface of the knife blade.

Any of these could be used to make a link to the mirror world space, yet none of them showed any abnormal sign.

But Duncan trusted Alice. She would not lie.

At some moment just now, the Frostholm inside the mirror world had overlapped with the Mortal Realm here. Perhaps the overlap had been very, very weak and brief, but it was still enough for the doll to catch the threads drifting over from that other side.

Chapter 397: City Hall

It was snowing.

The spell of clear, fine weather had not lasted long at all before another snowfall came to Frostholm. From early morning, heavy, leaden clouds had pressed over the city-state, and a wild cold wind had blown through the streets without rest. As the time neared noon, snowflakes began to fall in thick, drifting curtains. From the Upper City to the Lower City, from every tower to every cramped alley, the whole city-state was wrapped in hazy, swirling snow.

The sudden snowfall made the streets much quieter.

The screech of a Steam Car's brakes broke the silence of the snowy street. A dark gray car stopped at the front steps of City Hall. The door opened, and Agatha, dressed in black, stepped down and walked toward the tall and solemn building before her, a large structure whose main color was pale gray.

She raised her head and looked up at the soaring main building of City Hall. This classical structure, passed down from the age of the monarchy, still kept the imposing presence of that earlier era. Its towering pillars, arches, and rolling rooflines looked grand no matter when one saw them. Although its name had changed from "Winter King's Court" to the "City Hall" of today, its status in the city-state had never changed.

It still stood as one of the two poles of authority in the city-state, facing the distant Silent Grand Cathedral across the city and together sheltering this

city of Boiling Gold. Buildings were history books built of stone. The changing powers and people who passed through them were no more than lines of text on the pages. The Queen's age, and the present system of Governors as well, would in the end become just another passage that history turned past.

Agatha suddenly frowned and raised a hand to pinch her temple.

She knew she had drifted off again, and like some overly sentimental poet she had started sighing over many things. She had been like this over the past two days. For no clear reason, she would slip into wild, pointless thoughts, or sink into a vague unease.

This was not a good sign. As the city-state's Gatekeeper, her state of mind had to stay tightly controlled. "Spacing out" was something she needed to avoid as much as possible.

Footsteps came from the direction of the main door, cutting off Agatha's thoughts. She looked up and saw a senior secretary in a deep blue coat already walking toward her.

"Lady Agatha," the young man who served as the Governor's aide stopped in front of her and bowed respectfully. "The Governor has been informed of your visit. He is waiting for you in the domed office."

"Saving the formalities is fine by me," Agatha nodded. "Lead the way."

On the top floor of City Hall, inside a large office crowned with a rounded dome, Frostholm's current Governor, Winston, sat behind a wide, curved desk.

He was a tall man, a little on the heavy side, wearing an impressive bright blue coat decorated with medals and sashes. The strain of managing a declining city-state seemed to have drained him. His hair had grown so thin it was on the brink of vanishing, and he had been forced to wear a curled

wig to cover his scalp. When Agatha entered the domed office, the Governor was fiddling with a delicate brass machine placed on his desk.

The complex device looked like a kind of miniature model. Its tightly meshed gears and linkages were as intricate as a work of art, and under Winston's hands it gave off crisp clicking sounds from time to time.

"I did not expect you to still have time to play with machine models amidst such busy affairs," Agatha said from in front of the desk. "I thought the situation in the city-state would be enough to keep you fully occupied."

"This is not a mere machine model. It is the next generation of minecart traction mechanism," Winston replied, lifting his head with a serious expression. "It can save thirty percent in power, and is more reliable and durable than the last generation. The city's troubles come one after another, but we cannot stop living and developing because of that."

Agatha made no comment.

Governor Winston was deeply in love with machinery and engineering. In his twelve years as Governor, he had poured most of his energy into supporting the engineering design offices and machine works. He had ambitious plans and seemed to hope that technical breakthroughs would solve the city-state's current difficulties, both by upgrading old facilities and by seeking new sources of economic power. But, well…

One could only say his ideas were good, his confidence was strong, and he had worked hard—but the Mortal Realm was full of obstacles.

"Advances in technology will let us upgrade the mining facilities at a cost we can bear, and more practical new machines can be exported to other city-states. Frostholm cannot live forever just by selling Boiling Gold," Winston went on when he noticed the Gatekeeper's flat reaction. He could

not help talking more. “The Boiling Gold mines are Frostholm’s foundation, but a pillar built on a single industry is far too fragile…”

“I am not an official in economics or technology,” Agatha had to remind him gently.

“Oh, right, I forgot myself,” Winston said, lifting a hand. He set the machine model aside and looked up at Agatha. “Then let us talk business. Lady Agatha, you seem to have something to say about the exploration work in the Second Waterway?”

“The exploration unit ran into trouble under the connecting shaft in Central District Two,” Agatha said directly. “That passage is close to the bottom of the Boiling Gold mines. Some of its side pipes show signs of having been modified, but the gate leading to the next connected section is sealed. I ordered the exploration unit that they may use force to break through obstacles in the Second Waterway. But my people reported that they saw City Hall’s lead seals and a plaque on that gate.”

“…City Hall’s lead seals and a plaque?” Winston clearly froze for a moment. The surprise on his face did not look fake. “Are you sure?”

Agatha studied the Governor’s expression. Only after a long moment did she say softly: “It seems you truly know nothing about it.”

“That’s a Second Waterway that’s been abandoned for half a century. The last time it was in service was in the age when Frostholm’s Queen ruled this city-state!” Winston threw up his hands, his expression a bit exaggerated. “Even if there are lead seals and plaques down there, they should be from the Queen’s era. How could there be things left behind by City Hall? Lady Agatha, do you think I secretly sealed that gate myself? What would be the point? To store treasure deep underground?”

“You really do not have any reason to do that,” Agatha nodded lightly. “If you actually wanted to hide some treasure, any other place in the city would be more reliable than the Second Waterway in a runaway state.”

“I would rather not hear you seriously spin out that sort of idea,” Winston waved a hand, but his face had already grown solemn. “Isn’t there a date or the name of the person in charge on that plaque? A proper plaque should have that. You should be able to tell very easily who locked that gate.”

“Sadly, all the writing has been corroded beyond recognition. Both the plaque and the lead seals have suffered very serious corrosion. In fact even the gate itself has become unusually fragile. We suspect the acidic environment of the strata near the mines accelerated the aging of the metal,” Agatha shook her head. “We can only be sure that the gate really was locked by City Hall. The Queen’s era would never have used seals of that type.”

Winston stood up. His expression showed a hint of irritation as he paced back and forth behind the wide curved desk. After a long time, he finally stopped and muttered: “If it really was left behind by City Hall, then it must have been a long time ago. It might even have been the very first, or the second city government after the end of the Queen’s era…”

“It seems your predecessors did not pass all their records on to their successors,” Agatha said.

“Or the chaos of those early days caused some of the records to be lost or destroyed,” Winston waved his hand. “But no matter what, it is not normal for there to be a section sealed by City Hall’s order in the depths beneath the very center of the city, and for that section to be part of the Second Waterway. Lady Agatha, we must find out the truth of this.”

“Of course. That is my duty,” Agatha nodded. Her expression relaxed a little. “I did not get the answer I wanted, but having your support is enough.

The exploration will continue. I will find out as soon as possible what lies behind that gate. If there is any new progress, the Church will share it with City Hall at once."

"That will be best," Winston nodded.

The atmosphere in the domed office loosened a little.

"Then I will not stay and trouble you further," Agatha said. "There are still many matters in the Second Waterway that I need to oversee in person."

She exchanged polite farewells with the Governor, then turned and left the domed office.

The Gatekeeper's figure vanished from the room. Only the sound of the Gatekeeper's cane and her heels striking the floor slowly faded away. Winston waited a long moment before letting out a soft breath. Then he frowned in puzzlement.

"…Lady Agatha didn't use the Ashen Wind to travel today…" The slightly overweight middle-aged Governor lifted his head and looked toward the direction Agatha had left. He murmured to himself: "So she can actually walk in and out through the front door like a normal person?"

Chapter 398: Crossing Waterways

Deep in the secret passage that led to the Second Waterway, Nemo held a consecrated lantern in one hand. He walked ahead to lead the way and said in a slightly gloating tone: “Our people already got the news. They pulled out and ‘cleaned’ all the traces down here. The Church’s people are drilling around under the central district and the western district—those spreading shadows should be their headache now.”

“I was worried you would take the chance to cause some trouble,” Duncan said casually. “After all, on the Second Waterway, this is your home turf.”

“We have no reason to do that.” Nemo shook his head. “We serve Captain Tyrian, and Captain Tyrian never wants this city-state destroyed. From the point of view of protecting the city, we don’t really clash with the Church, or even City Hall. Right now the Church’s people are trying to clear out the cultists in the city. We’re not so hot-headed we would do something that helps those cultists.”

Duncan nodded, then asked with some curiosity: “Old Ghost didn’t show up today?”

“Old Ghost…” Nemo hesitated, then let out a light sigh. “Old Ghost’s mental state has been more and more unstable. He’s too old. The Church’s search of the Second Waterway also rattled his nerves. It made him recall the fighting in the sewers back then. To avoid an accident, I had to leave him resting in the tavern cellar.”

The last Warrior who had once served the Queen still could not walk out of that nightmare from decades ago. Duncan could only sigh at that, then he and Alice went on in silence toward the depths of the Second Waterway.

They passed through the secret passage, went through several hidden doors and intersections that seemed to be watched by hidden sentries, and in the end entered the Second Waterway again along a route completely different from last time.

It was clear that, to deal with the search operations of the Church and the authority, the Sea Mist Fleet Informants hidden in the city-state had activated a long-prepared system of disguises and early warnings.

In the end, Duncan and Alice, led by Nemo, returned to that corridor again —the place where Crow had met with his accident.

“I’ll head back now,” Nemo said to Duncan. “Things are tense in the city. There are more and more people watching us. I have to keep an eye on what’s happening above. You should be careful of the Church down here…”

He had wanted to remind Duncan to be careful in case he ran into a Church search team here. But halfway through, he suddenly felt something was off. He swallowed his words for a long moment, then forced out: “Maybe go easy on them. They’re actually not bad people…”

Duncan could not help but laugh. “You don’t have to worry. I know my limits. Go on back. You’ve already been away from the tavern too long.”

“Okay.”

Nemo left quickly, and the wide, chilly underground waterway fell quiet for a moment.

Duncan raised his head and looked at the empty corridor ahead. In his mind, he recalled what it had been like when he came here last time.

The young man called Crow had fallen by the sewage channel not far ahead. He had died on the dry ground, but his cause of death was drowning in seawater. In his pocket, someone had stuffed a record of “Sacred Script” copied from some unknown place.

Now the corridor had already been cleaned. It had probably been Nemo and Old Ghost who did it.

Duncan turned his head and saw Alice following honestly at his side. The eyes that showed from under her veil looked serious—but he knew this Doll was actually spacing out and not thinking about anything at all.

Of course Duncan knew he couldn’t rely on this Doll to discuss or reason through anything. He had brought Alice only because she could see those “threads”—even the threads that sometimes leaked out when the mirror world world drew close could not escape her eyes.

“If you see the threads again, tell me at once,” Duncan said seriously.

“Mm-hmm!” Alice nodded right away.

Duncan walked forward slowly.

In his mind, he was still thinking about Crow.

At the time, he and Morris and the others had guessed that Crow had stumbled into some place by mistake and that was why disaster fell on him. But in the end, they had searched the whole corridor and found no clues. The investigation had hit a dead end. Now, though… it seemed the place Crow had stumbled into finally had an answer.

Most likely, mirror world Frostholm had briefly overlapped with Mortal Realm Frostholm in this corridor. It might have been a crack, or a fleeting reflection on some pool of water. Crow had just been passing by and fell into it by bad luck.

No matter how he had crossed that boundary back then, one thing was clear:

This corridor should be a weak point that connected the mirror world and the Mortal Realm.

…

Underground, it was cold and damp. The air was full of the moldy smell of rot. It felt as if the whole city-state was a corpse that was slowly rotting away—and she was walking inside the organs of this rotten corpse.

Footsteps echoed in the foul-smelling corridor of the sewers. They sounded a bit heavy. Agatha walked forward slowly. At the same time, she used temporary Divination and Spiritual Insight to feel out and confirm the direction, while carefully watching for any change in the air around her.

Her black clothes were badly torn. The soft armor under them and the ritual bandages wrapped around her body were stained with more blood. The damage to her body had passed the point where it could repair itself. She could only use divine magic to stop the bleeding for now. She had no time to think about healing flesh and bone.

The good news was that Agatha felt more and more sure she was moving in the right direction. After destroying more and more replica freaks, after clashing several times with this hostile replica city, she could finally “smell” the Heretics’ presence more and more clearly.

Following this scent, she walked through the streets and alleys of the Lower City, passed through empty, twisted subway tunnels, then crawled into the collapsed sewers. In the end, she discovered this world deep beneath the city-state that had been abandoned for who knew how many years.

Its vastness went beyond what she had seen in the records in the archives, and beyond what she had imagined from those files.

Agatha raised her head and looked at the wide corridor ahead, lit only by dim light. Old gas lamps were set into the walls on both sides. Their flames flickered, starved of gas. The light wavered and jumped inside the glass covers. On the arched ceiling of the corridor, she could see crisscrossing pipes and support beams. Under the shaking light of the gas lamps, everything cast twisting, shifting shadows, as if countless unseen things were crawling in the gloom.

On both sides of the floor ran channels full of filthy water. Sickening black water poured down from grates in the walls and merged into the channels, making a constant rushing sound.

Agatha knew what this place was.

This was the “Second Waterway” under Frostholm—the place she had originally planned to explore with a team.

The only difference from her plan was that she had planned to explore the underground of the city in the Mortal Realm world. Now she was trapped inside a copied Frostholm.

Agatha closed her eyes a little and carefully felt how the air moved. She shut out the filthy stench and relied on her intuition as a Spiritual Insight to search for the Heretics’ location.

She could feel that the longer she stayed here, and the more she dealt with these freaks, the stronger the “link” between her and this replica city became.

Up ahead.

The Gatekeeper opened her eyes. She ignored the faint pain from the wounds all over her body, chose one of the branches in front of her, and went deeper down the corridor.

She suddenly remembered something.

Not long ago, she had visited the being who had descended in Frostholm, the one who might have been an Elder God, or the avatar form of an Elder God. Back then, that being had hinted to her that she should go “underground” to look for clues.

Now, guided by the traces in the air, she was going closer and closer to the Heretics’ lair.

The Heretics really were hiding under the city, hidden in this abandoned Second Waterway—but this “underground hideout” was not under the Frostholm of the Mortal Realm. It was in this strange realm, inside a city copied from the original.

Agatha tugged at the corner of her mouth.

The road twisted, but in the end it brought her back to the starting point.

She had misunderstood the hint of the Descended One and had thought the enemy was hiding in the Second Waterway of the Mortal Realm world. Now, by a strange turn of fate, she had entered this replica city and found clues in this replica Second Waterway instead.

To wander at all the forks and finally walk onto the right path—was that also a kind of luck?

Agatha studied her surroundings.

She had never explored the Second Waterway in the Mortal Realm world in depth, but she did know a few basic facts. She knew that old sewer system had long been abandoned and sealed. All pipes, shafts, and drains that led to the Second Waterway had been closed. In theory, it should be a dry or mostly dry place.

But in the sewer corridor in front of her, she could see flowing sewage everywhere. She could also hear drainage sounds from the pipes around her from time to time.

In this copied Frostholm, the Second Waterway looked as if it was still in regular use. Was this also one of the differences between a replica and the real thing?

Agatha thought about this, then suddenly stopped walking.

Sticky, disgusting slithering sounds came from around her. black sludge was seeping out from the openings of the waste pipes and from the walls covered with black corruption.

Those relentless freaks had come again.

Her body was very tired. Her wounds were aching. The ritual bandages were already torn. The God of Death’s divine blessing was slowly fading. The weakness from blood loss had reached a level she could no longer ignore.

But Agatha only raised her head calmly. Her gaze fell on the twisted monsters gathering in front of her.

“Come,” she said. “Come die.”

Chapter 399: Connection

When the first deformed freak rushed at her with a roar, Agatha only shifted her body a little to the side. At the moment they passed each other, she tapped the monster's limb lightly with her Gatekeeper's cane. The creature burst at once into Cremation Fire. Before that pale flame could hit the floor, she lifted her Gatekeeper's cane and pointed forward. She drew a blinding white line out from the flame. It fell into the junction ahead and spread like flowing fire, burning the ugly monsters there.

She tried her best not to make big movements, to lessen the strain of tiredness and pain. At the same time, she tried to avoid direct contact with the freaks as much as she could, so she would not spend too much of her strength and spirit. She did not know how many endless monsters were waiting for her ahead. She had to save her strength.

She did not resist death. She knew that even after this body died, it could still fight until it became ash. That ash would float in this cursed place and keep purifying these disgusting monsters. She had never feared any of that. But before she embraced death, she still wanted to find out the truth here and do all she could to stop the Heretics' plans.

Along the way, she had been attacked more and more often. The movements of the twisted freaks grew more and more frantic. This had already faintly proved one thing—she had chosen the right direction. The lair of the Heretics lay ahead.

More black sludge seeped from the nearby walls and from the arching ceiling. Every gap and every crack between the bricks here was a breeding

ground for these twisted things. Because of the terrain, the way these replicas appeared was becoming more eerie and more troublesome.

A faint hissing sound came from behind her, to the side. Agatha felt a warning rise in her heart. Her body felt slow with fatigue. At the crucial moment, she barely managed to twist around and bring up her Gatekeeper's cane to block.

A sharp stab of pain shot from her shoulder. Sparks burst from the middle of the Gatekeeper's cane. A black-clad figure who also held a Gatekeeper's cane in his hand was knocked flying.

The figure hit the ground, then crawled back up again, squirming like some disgusting soft-bodied creature. He lifted his head. Under his black hat was a face that seemed to be melting, slowly flowing and twisting out of shape. In that horrible face, she could still faintly pick out some familiar lines.

In the next second, that flowing face solidified. It became a young man with clear, sharp features. He looked up at Agatha with a confused expression and said: "Captain? What are you doing here?"

Agatha's fingers tightened around her Gatekeeper's cane until they turned slightly white. Her eyes froze for a second.

Almost at the same time, she heard a voice.

She did not know where it came from. It was as if the whole sewer was echoing. The voice whispered to her:

"Ah, you recognized him. Back when you were not yet a Gatekeeper, your loyal vice-captain covered your retreat from the darkness… You left him there… Take him back with you, how about it?"

Agatha gave no answer. She only walked forward in silence. After three steps, she turned into a gust of Ashen Wind. The wind stopped and gathered in front of the young "Guardian." When her figure appeared again, her tin

Gatekeeper’s cane was already buried deep in the chest of the black-clad Guardian.

The young black-clad guard stared at the scene in shock, as if he could not believe he would die at the hands of the “Captain” he trusted so much. Then suddenly, he seemed to understand something. A soft whisper came from his throat: “So it’s finally over…”

“Sorry,” Agatha said softly. “It will be over soon.”

The young black-clad guard slowly lowered his head and let out a small laugh. “Captain, you finally mastered the power of Ashen Wind…”

“Yes. I trained for a long time.” Agatha spoke softly. Pale flame rose before her eyes. The black-clad guard’s body melted and broke apart in the Cremation Fire, turning into a pile of black dust.

“Decisive. Cold. Very fitting for your role as the God of Death’s Saint.”

That disgusting voice echoed again. Agatha turned around and saw more twisted freaks taking shape. replicas surged at her from all directions. Their Master clearly knew nothing of Knightly spirit. Even while he tried to attack her heart, he kept sending these lackeys to attack her.

The sound of exploding flames, of the Gatekeeper’s cane striking back, and of air being torn apart echoed in the underground corridor. While Agatha held off the twisted things, she spoke in a low voice: “These little tricks can only anger me. They can’t slow my steps. On the contrary, anger only makes me find your lair faster. How does that help you?”

“…True enough. You’re angry. You look even fiercer than before. But that’s fine—some emotional fluctuation is quite necessary, Miss Gatekeeper.”

The voice that echoed in the corridor seemed to drift farther away. Agatha’s heart gave a little jolt.

Some emotional fluctuation is quite necessary? What was that supposed to mean?

But there was no one left here to answer her question. The Master of that voice had only one goal: to use cannon fodder to slowly wear down her strength and delay her steps. Now he had gone. The only things left here were yet another batch of monsters that had just “seeped” out from the walls around her.

Agatha’s eyes sharpened. She went to meet her enemies again.

…

“Our Warrior is fighting the enemy!”

A streak of green fire suddenly tore through the gloom of the Second Waterway. The shape of the pigeon, AI, shot out from the flames and crashed straight down onto Duncan’s shoulder. It flapped its wings hard and let out sharp, shrill cries.

The stupid bird that had suddenly burst out, and its piercing screech, made Duncan jump. It almost scared Alice’s head right off.

Duncan had already been searching this dry, empty underground corridor for quite a while. Now he stared and turned his head to look at the Pigeon Spirit burning all over on his shoulder: “What are you screeching about?”

AI tilted its head. Its small eyes stared straight at Duncan. It nodded with a serious look and said: “Our Scout Maiden was attacked! Our Scout Maiden was attacked! The battle is going badly for us… Our Warrior is fighting the enemy!”

Alice came over, holding her head. “Captain, did AI eat something bad?”

AI turned its head and glared at the Doll. It stretched out its neck and pecked twice at her skull, making a hollow “thunk, thunk” sound. Then it

squawked at the top of its lungs: “Is that okay, is that okay, is that okay…”

Alice let out a yelp at the pecks, hugged her head, and ran.

Duncan did not pay much attention to the ruckus beside him. The moment he heard AI shout the same thing the second time, his face had already grown serious. Right after that, he looked thoughtfully in one direction.

“You two, quiet,” he said suddenly after a few seconds, breaking the silence. His face looked especially grave as he stared toward a junction on the other side of the corridor. “AI might have sensed something.”

Alice went quiet at once and looked in the direction of Duncan’s gaze.

“It’s the mark I left… It’s that ‘Gatekeeper,’” Duncan said as he stepped forward. “She’s nearby.”

Alice stared at that direction, then suddenly her eyes widened.

“Ah, there are threads!”

The Doll Miss let out a short cry, then rushed over at once—she even ran faster than Duncan. She was like an anxious child trying to grab a balloon that was about to fly away. She ran straight to the junction and then jumped up, grabbing at something invisible in the air.

Duncan only saw Alice run ahead and jump around, trying to grab at the air. Then he seemed to faintly see something appear in Alice’s hand.

They were white, almost transparent, and they bent the light of the corridor just a little… threads.

He walked over quickly. Alice turned her head, and a bright, happy smile spread over her face.

“I caught—”

The Doll Miss’s happy smile lasted only a moment. In the next second, the faint threads in her hand suddenly began to break and snap. They crumbled and faded away quickly in the air, as if they were weathering at high speed.

“Ah!” Alice cried out. “The threads broke!”

Before her cry had even finished, a tall, broad-shouldered figure had already strode up from the side. Duncan reached toward the breaking, weathering “threads”—and a little piece of thread that was about to vanish completely fell into his hand.

In an instant, a layer of ghostly green fire spread along the line.

Duncan slowly turned his head. He looked into Alice’s eyes. In Alice’s wide eyes, a small flicker of ghostly green danced.

“I’ve got it,” Duncan said softly.

…

One twisted freak turned to ash in pale flame. Another had its head smashed by the Gatekeeper’s cane and slumped down like soft mud. Agatha turned her body. The fighting Gatekeeper’s cane in her hand sliced through the air and came down hard toward the last enemy still standing at the junction.

Then her movement suddenly stopped.

It was pure instinct. She had no time to think. Huge fear and awe slammed straight into her mind and froze it. She even felt her muscles and bones let out a sharp, awful creaking sound. A powerful force from her Spiritual Insight—maybe even a direct warning from the God of Death, Bartok—suddenly halted her attack.

She saw her Gatekeeper’s cane stop. It hung there, less than a few millimeters from the head of the last “replica” that had just crawled out of the sludge.

Her eyes opened wide as she watched the human-shaped figure, its whole body made from flowing mud, slowly raise its head. A pair of eyes slowly formed where its head should be. ghostly green flame began to burn along the surface of its body. A deep voice crackled out from within the fire:

“Agatha, need help?”

Chapter 400: Traveling the Waterway Together

Agatha instantly withdrew the Gatekeeper's cane, then widened her eyes, staring in shock and wariness at the "replica" monster in front of her that was slowly raising its head. In that instant, she realized that this monster, whose "mud" body was made of elements, had already mutated.

Some power or will had descended into its body and instantly changed its nature. It had turned into a medium, and in this dark sewer it kept releasing a terrifying power.

Layer upon layer of noise rose up, turning in her mind into countless incomprehensible whispers and roars. Agatha felt trembling shadows spreading at the edges of her vision, and in those shadows it was as if countless eyes opened at once. This was a sign that her spirit was suffering corruption. The exhaustion and mental damage built up from continuous battles had weakened her defenses, leaving her almost unable to resist.

But this corruption lasted for less than two seconds. It seemed the master of that power had deliberately taken control and reined in the might spilling out from this avatar form. Agatha's senses cleared and steadied again, and in that brief clarity she realized the "identity" of the person before her.

"You are… that Descended One…" She rubbed her forehead and spoke hesitantly.

"It's me," that avatar form said. The body of elements sludge still writhed and changed, as if it could not bear such overwhelming power, and it never

managed to take on a clear, stable shape. “Just call me Captain—my followers all call me that.”

“Captain?” Agatha frowned. The aftereffects of the mental corruption made her thoughts a little slow. She felt the title was a bit odd, but soon gave up worrying about it. There were countless “captains” in the world. A high? ranking supernatural of unknown origin might call himself “Captain” just for fun. That was not something worth digging into.

“Why are you here?” she asked in confusion.

“I’ve been looking for you for a long time,” Duncan said. “When you suddenly vanished from the city?state, I knew something had happened to you.”

“You were looking for me?” Agatha was a little stunned. Then she quickly lifted her head and scanned the surroundings. “How are things ‘outside’?”

“If you mean the Frostholm in the Mortal Realm, then everything is as usual—as usual to an abnormal degree,” Duncan shook his head. “Do you know where you’re trapped?”

“I… I’m not sure.” Agatha propped herself up with the Gatekeeper’s cane and slowly leaned against the wall. She had finally gained a precious moment of safety and had to use it to recover a bit of strength. “This is another Frostholm, a Frostholm completely controlled by ‘replicas’. There is no Sun here, and the link to the God is very weak. But there are traces of those Annihilation heretics. I was tracking one of them and chased him all the way here…”

She stopped, panting a little, and turned to look at the “Captain”.

“A mirror world,” that temporary avatar form said. “You’re trapped inside Frostholm’s mirror world.”

“mirror world?” Agatha’s eyes widened for a moment. Then she lowered her head, looking thoughtful. “So that’s it… a mirror world…”

“They may have copied the entire Frostholm, including the waters around it. This mirror world is the source of all the ‘replicas’,” Duncan went on. “The trouble is, there are signs that this mirror world and the Mortal Realm are slowly drawing closer. That should be the Annihilators’ real plan.”

Agatha snapped her head up: “You mean…”

“The ‘replicas’ appearing so often in the city?state, the copied Sea Swallow, the vanished Dagger Island, even you being trapped here—all of that is the result of ‘mirror world Frostholm’ drawing closer and closer to ‘Mortal Realm Frostholm’. The Annihilators never meant to invade or destroy this city, Agatha. What they want is to transform the entire city into the ‘kingdom’ from the prophecy.”

“…At some point, the approaching mirror world and the Mortal Realm will collide…” Agatha drew in a slow breath and muttered. She had already thought of that possibility. “No wonder, no wonder that heretic said that when the Guardian found the ‘sanctuary’, it would mean their plan had succeeded… that moment would be the moment the mirror world touched the Mortal Realm!”

“Sounds like you already have an idea,” Duncan said. “You just said you found traces of those cultists here and were tracking them?”

“Yes. I smelled their scent—deep inside this ‘second waterway’.” Agatha raised her head and looked toward some point deep down the corridor. After a brief rest, she had recovered some strength. She braced herself, stood straight again, and slowly walked forward. “There is a heretic. He kept trying to stop me. But the longer he pestered me, the more he exposed his own trail. I feel I’m very close…”

The avatar form under Duncan’s control followed after Agatha.

“I’m very sorry.” Agatha, who was walking in front, suddenly spoke.

“Why apologize?”

“Just now… I almost attacked you.” Agatha’s tone sounded a little embarrassed.

Duncan paused in surprise, then recalled what he had seen when he had just entered this avatar form—the tin Gatekeeper’s cane in Agatha’s hand had been only a few millimeters from his head.

But he thought about it and decided it wasn’t a big deal.

At least it was better than Vanna’s jumping slash back then.

“I don’t mind. I’m already used to it.”

“…Used to it?”

“One of my followers likes to use a jumping slash whenever she gets frightened—sometimes the target is me, though she doesn’t do that anymore.”

Agatha: “…?”

The young Gatekeeper was deeply shaken. She could not help guessing what the daily life of this suspected Elder God was like with his followers, and what kind of outrageous, strange, and uncanny beings those followers were.

She thought about it for a long time, but even with her sanity score almost emptied, she still could not figure it out.

Duncan did not care about Agatha’s sudden daze and thoughts. He just kept walking forward, carefully observing the corridor as they went.

This was the second waterway of mirror world Frostholm—and it was clearly very different from the second waterway in the Mortal Realm.

He stopped and looked ahead, thoughtful, at the sewer corridor stretching on in the dim light.

“Did something occur to you?” Agatha also stopped and looked back at him in confusion.

“In the Mortal Realm, this area collapsed and the passage is blocked,” Duncan said, his tone thoughtful. “But in this mirror world Frostholm, the second waterway is intact. It even looks like it has been in constant use.”

“…Maybe it’s showing how it looked in the Queen’s era,” Agatha said hoarsely. “I’ve already noticed that many details in this mirror world Frostholm look almost like the scenes I’m familiar with, but not quite. It doesn’t look modern.”

Duncan listened to Agatha’s analysis and did not speak for a moment. After a few seconds, he finally broke the silence: “Looks like I may not be able to accompany you for the rest of the way.”

Agatha turned back in surprise.

She saw the Captain’s avatar form gradually breaking apart. The flowing, shifting black sludge that made up his body seemed to be bearing a power that was far too great. Now it was flaking away bit by bit, leaving crisscrossing, web?like cracks on the surface of that body. Between those cracks, Ghost?green flames leapt about, looking as if they were going to spill out of control.

She blurted out without thinking: “Your body…”

“Don’t worry about it. This shoddy replica can’t stably bear my power. It’s only a matter of time before it collapses,” Duncan just shook his head, his

tone calm. “It’s already surprising it held together long enough for me to say this much to you.”

Then he waved his hand, stopping Agatha from speaking.

“Your state is very bad. You need more help. I’ll leave some Fire Seed here. That Fire Seed can strengthen the link between you and me. Take it and keep tracking those cultists’ lair—I will keep helping you.”

Agatha stepped forward on instinct, as if she still wanted to ask something. But before she could speak, that avatar form, which had already been pushed to the limit by too much power, finally reached its end.

In a sudden surge of eerie green flames, the elements sludge that formed the avatar form stopped flowing. The fire devoured it and tore it apart, and countless ashen fragments scattered with a roar.

In the center of the charred black elements remains, only a tiny flame the size of a finger was left.

The little flame floated in midair near the ground.

Agatha stared blankly at the flame drifting near the ground. Its ghostly green color made the Gatekeeper wary. She instinctively felt fear and tension. Yet after a moment of hesitation, she still stepped forward and slowly bent down.

“…I hope this is the right choice.”

She spoke softly and silently recited Bartok’s name in her heart. Then she reached out, as if mustering all her courage, and her fingertip touched the tiny flame.

The flame felt like a weightless petal as she lifted it into her hand.

“…I really can pick it up.”

Agatha stared in surprise at the flame resting in her palm. At that moment, she felt a connection between herself and the fire.

It was weak and strange, but real. After a brief daze she came back to herself, carefully cupped the flame in her hand, picked up the battered Gatekeeper’s cane with the other, and stepped toward the deepest part of the second waterway.

Chapter 401: Fog?

In the center of the city?state, at the highest point of Frostholm, the Silent Cathedral stood quietly atop the mountain. The gloomy sky made the solemn, dark building seem even heavier with muted oppression. Its forest of spires stood in the thin mist like thorns and blades, overlooking the entire city.

A tall figure, especially eye?catching among the crowd, strolled across the square in front of the Cathedral, looking around at the sights like an ordinary tourist.

Before long, another elderly gentleman in a dark brown coat, with a gentle, scholarly air, walked out of the crowd and headed straight toward that tall figure.

Vanna saw Morris coming out of the crowd and quietly moved to a relatively secluded spot.

“There is no anomaly on the Cathedral square.” Vanna leaned against a streetlamp and looked at the Cathedral’s main doors in the distance, speaking in a low voice.

“Same at City Hall. At least on the surface, there are no signs that the people there have suffered any mental or cognitive corruption,” Morris said as he wiped his blessed monocle. “But I did notice something.”

“Something?”

“People near the square were talking about the recent sewer exploration operation by The authority. If I’m not wrong, they were talking about the second waterway,” Morris said. “They mentioned Gatekeeper Agatha—that Gatekeeper is personally leading the team.”

“Gatekeeper Agatha?” Vanna’s expression changed a little. “But the Captain said…”

“The real Agatha should be trapped right now in a Frostholm city that has become a mirror world,” Morris said in a low voice. “The one leading the team… is most likely a replica.”

Vanna drew in a deep breath, then suddenly looked up toward the Silent Cathedral.

The majestic building stood against the gloomy sky, its many spires standing in the mist without a sound.

Her expression grew grim: “…The Grand Cathedral shows no sign of anything wrong, so there are only two possibilities. Either the replica has fooled the Grand Cathedral’s eyes, or…”

“Or Frostholm Church is no longer trustworthy. At the very least, something is very wrong inside the Grand Cathedral,” Morris nodded slightly. “Whichever it is, Frostholm Church has clearly lost control of this whole affair—we should leave. We have to tell Mr. Duncan about this at once.”

Vanna nodded silently and walked with Morris toward the exit at the edge of the square. Before leaving, she again looked up one last time at the open area opposite the Silent Cathedral.

That was where City Hall stood, the Queen’s palace that had once been called the ‘Winter Court’. Fog had formed atop the hill. In the thickening mist, Vanna saw that building standing as silent under the sky as the Silent Cathedral. Its spires were tall, its towers crowded together. One high tower

after another rose like thorns and blades in the mist, quietly overlooking the city.

Vanna's steps suddenly stopped.

Morris immediately turned his head: "Vanna? What did you see?"

Vanna stared hard at that hazy mist.

As the mist curled, City Hall returned to its original look. It was a palace? like building with all kinds of curved vaults. Around the dignified gray? white main hall stretched long halls like wings, their vaulted roofs rising and falling in a row.

There were no gloomy black spires and no forest of high towers.

"Vanna? What's wrong?" Morris's voice came again beside her.

"I just saw another Grand Cathedral—right where City Hall is," Vanna said suddenly in a low voice, her expression especially grave. "It was only for a moment, but I'm sure I didn't see it wrong!"

"Another Grand Cathedral?" Morris was startled. He instinctively looked across the square, but all he saw was the perfectly normal City Hall.

But he did not doubt Vanna's judgment at all.

"This is not a good sign," the old scholar said in a deep voice, raising a hand to press down his hat. "It seems only you saw that scene. That may be because your Spirit Sight as clergy is far beyond ordinary people. That manifestation appeared directly around the Grand Cathedral. That is proof the corruption is getting worse."

Vanna did not respond. She only frowned deeply and looked toward the city at the foot of the hill. After a long moment, she spoke slowly: "It's getting foggy. Everywhere."

Fog had formed. At first it was only in the central area of the Frostholm city?state. Then the mist began to spread across the whole urban district. It started as faint wisps, then quickly grew thick. In just a few hours, the entire city was wrapped in haze.

“It’s so foggy outside!”

Shirley leaned over the second?floor bedroom window, craning her neck to look at the street. She shouted with a look of surprise on her face.

Dog also pressed against the window, his ugly skull head squeezed next to Shirley’s. After staring outside for a long time, he suddenly spoke up: “The reason for heavy fog in urban areas is usually a large temperature difference between day and night, plus human activity causing water vapor to rise and dust in the air to increase. The moist air between buildings then meets a sudden drop in temperature and forms…”

Shirley listened, completely lost: “Dog, what are you talking about?”

“Dog is reciting the second chapter of The Logic Behind Nature. It’s been reading that book these past two days,” Nina said offhandedly, glancing over from the desk where she was doing homework. “You should try reading some simple books yourself sometimes. It really helps with learning more words—if it’s too hard, you can start with picture books.”

Shirley thought for a moment and said uncertainly: “Are you mocking me for knowing so few words, that after all this time I can still only read picture books?”

Nina had already turned her attention back to her homework: “No, because you really can only read picture books. Stating facts doesn’t count as mocking…”

Shirley’s eyes went wide, as if she wanted to get angry, but the thicker fog outside caught her attention again. She waved her hand. “Ah, I’m not

arguing with you about this—come look! The fog outside is really thick! Even back in Pland I never saw fog this heavy…”

“Pland doesn’t have a big temperature difference between day and night, and it’s windy in the morning and evening. It’s not easy for fog to form there,” Nina said without looking up. “I’m not looking. I haven’t finished my homework. The practice papers Teacher Morris assigned are really hard, and the multiple?choice questions are so confusing. I keep feeling I picked the wrong answers…”

“Hey, when you run into a question you can’t solve, just choose C for everything,” Shirley said casually. Then her eyes rolled, as if a new idea had popped up. “Nina, do you want to go out and play? Just nearby, we won’t go far. There’s a pastry shop across the street. In this weather there definitely won’t be many guests. Maybe we can buy cake really cheap…”

“I’m not going,” Nina said. “If you want to go, go by yourself. When Uncle Duncan comes back, I just won’t tell on you…”

She had only said half a sentence when a strange rustling sound suddenly rose in the room, cutting off the two girls’ conversation.

“Did you… just hear something?” Shirley quickly jumped back from the window and looked around warily.

Nina tensed up too. As she instinctively tried to look around, the corner of her eye suddenly caught something strange on the surface of the test papers and books spread out in front of her.

The words were moving, the symbols were spinning, and the clear black ink strokes trembled as if they had come alive. Along the edges of those shaking lines, black shadows spread like spilled ink and quickly filled the whole sheet.

In almost an instant, all the books and papers Nina had been reading began to shake violently. Layered whispers and murmurs mixed with that rustling sound and echoed through the whole room!

“Ah! Your books are possessed!” Shirley cried out. At the same time, she instinctively raised the chain that linked her to Dog. The moment her shout fell, the thing that had followed the scent of knowledge upward toward the Mortal Realm also entered the room!

The black smoke and dust spun wildly. A body condensed and appeared out of the smoke. Fragments of bone scattered across the floor with a clatter and in an instant turned into ugly, terrifying demons—three Abyssal Hounds landed on the floor, letting out fearsome growls. Their chaotic, blood?red eye sockets were filled with madness and disorder!

Then they saw Dog sprawled on the open patch of floor by the window, looking a little dazed.

The Abyssal Hounds looked at one another—Shirley even felt she saw a flash of confusion in the posture of those chaotic, witless “native demons”.

But that did not affect her reaction at all.

The pitch?black chains rattled at once. Shirley raised her arm high. With tremendous force, she swung Dog in a full circle like a flail, and in the next second sent him whistling toward the demon closest to the window!

“I’m gonna beat you to death!”

With a thunderous crash, the two dog heads collided with earth?shaking force. The demon that had just rushed up from the Abyssal Deep Sea, clearly could not compare with Dog, who had been sparring with Shirley for years—whether in skull hardness or in reaction speed.

The first Abyssal demon was smashed to pieces in a single hit.

The second Abyssal demon only had time to open its mouth. Before it could let out a roar, it suddenly felt a surge of intense heat rushing at it.

A streak of flame shot in from the side as Nina raised her leg in a 6000? Degree Flying Kick.

Chapter 402: Pervading

After spending some time adapting to life on the ship, Nina had gotten used to the little problems that came with reading and studying. Those problems included, but were not limited to, shadows surfacing from the Spirit Realm, demons appearing from the Abyssal Deep, and strange changes in the books themselves. On top of that, thanks to all her hard training, her control over her own power had greatly improved.

Specifically, even when she lifted her leg for a 6,000-degree flying kick, she could now make sure she did not set the bedding on the nearby bunk on fire.

A flash of blinding light swept past. Demons from the deep layers of the world turned to ash in an instant under the power of the Sun. The air did not even have time to pick up the stench of burning. There was only the warm smell of blankets that had been dried in noon sunlight.

The last Abyssal Hound that the book had attracted was left alone in the middle of the room. Even though it was a Abyssal demon with a chaotic, almost brainless mind that acted on pure instinct, this terrifying creature still seemed to fall into a brief daze. It could not seem to understand why it had suddenly lost two companions. Now, in front of it, Dog was bending low with the chain in Shirley’s hand and growling. Behind it, Nina walked forward step by step, wrapped in light like a blazing sun.

The terrible pressure from behind it was far stronger than the strange “kin” in front of it.

The Abyssal demon turned its head on instinct and met a gaze as scorching as the Sun.

Nina lowered her head a little. Her hair was now fully dyed with a golden sheen. Harsh light leaked from her seven orifices. Within this Human shell, the power of the Ancient Sun burned. When she turned her gaze on the demon, the bones in the creature's body began to burn under her eyes.

Shirley was frightened. She had never seen Nina angry before. She had even thought that this friend, who was always as bright and cheerful as sunlight, never got mad at all. Now she knew she had been very wrong. Nina was clearly very angry.

Her fury rose like a solar prominence. Even though she held back the heat that was leaking out, the light still felt so bright it could burn a person's soul.

As Shirley grew more and more nervous and finally could not help wanting to speak, Nina at last opened her mouth. Searing plasma flames leaked from the corner of her lips. Her voice boomed:

"My homework!" Her voice even carried grief and rage. "My test papers! My reference books! And Shirley's homework! These mutts tore them all to shreds!"

The wrath of the Sun scared the demons so badly that they lost all ability to move. When Shirley heard what Nina said, she was even more shocked. She almost laughed out loud. "Really? My homework is gone too?"

But in the next second she came back to herself. She hurried to stop Nina, who was about to avenge the homework with a flying kick. "Ah, wait! Leave this demon alive for now! Dog has questions!"

Nina already had her leg raised, but when she heard her friend shout, she still stopped on instinct. She glanced sideways at Shirley. "What is there to

ask? It’s just a Abyssal demon that sneaks in to make trouble when people are reading. We’ve already killed a bunch of them on the ship…”

“But it’s daytime!” Shirley shouted.

Nina froze for a moment. Then she suddenly realized.

It was daytime. Even though a thick fog had risen outside and the sky had grown as dim as dusk, in terms of time it was still daytime. It was still the time when Vision 001 covered the world.

At this time of day, the city-states were safe. Reading would not draw in invaders from the dark. So why had these Abyssal demons appeared?

Nina’s gaze (6,000°C) instantly locked on the last Abyssal Hound.

Bathed in the light of a star at point-blank range, the bones all over the demon’s body began to smoke. It struggled on instinct. It seemed to want to open a rift and flee back to the Abyssal Deep. But its instinctive escape was cut off at once.

Dog disrupted the half-formed crack that had just appeared beside the demon.

“Can you get anything out of it?” Nina pulled back some of her power and looked at Dog with curiosity. “Didn’t you say normal Abyssal demons don’t have much mind at all and can’t be talked to?”

“Brainless is still brainless, but if you really investigate, you can still dig out a little,” Dog said as he shook his head. It looked like his head was still buzzing a bit from headbutting the other Abyssal Hound earlier. “They do have memories. And now and then their chaotic thoughts hold a few connected pieces. Don’t worry. Abyssal demons have their own way of ‘talking’.”

“What way of talking?” Nina and Shirley asked at the same time.

“…Not a very pretty one,” Dog muttered. He slowly walked toward the Abyssal Hound that had almost stopped struggling under the blazing sun. Then he lifted his head and glanced at Shirley. “Close your eyes, Shirley.”

Shirley paused for a second, then obediently shut her eyes.

There was a short growl and the sounds of a scuffle. Right after that came the noise of bones being torn, crushed, and chewed. In the tooth-aching creak and crack, the demon’s violent struggle lasted only a brief moment.

After a while, Shirley cautiously opened her eyes again. On the floor in the center of the room there was nothing left but a small pile of black dust that was fading away fast. Dog stood next to the pile. Nina stood across from him, staring blankly for a moment. Only after quite some time did the blazing sunlight around her slowly fade. Then she let out a low gasp: “Wow…”

Shirley guessed what had happened while her eyes were closed. She gave Dog a slightly complicated look. “Actually… I don’t really…”

“You’d have nightmares. I know you,” Dog said, shaking his head. Then he ground his teeth and spat to the side with open disgust. “Ptoo.”

“Did it hurt your teeth?”

“Chewing on a demon that can’t even read is like chewing on a rock. I couldn’t squeeze even a full sentence out of it,” Dog said, clearly disgusted by his illiterate cousin. “And this fellow even ran out chasing after knowledge.”

He grumbled as he showed all the confidence and pride of a cultured dog. Then he lowered his head, as if he were carefully feeling out the information he had just gained from that “talk.”

A moment later, he raised his head again with a puzzled look and glanced at Shirley and Nina. “Strange… The last memories left in this Abyssal Hound

say that it has never once felt the suppression of Vision 001…”

Shirley and Nina stared at each other in shock.

“But right now… it’s clearly daytime…”

Shirley muttered under her breath. She slowly walked to the window and leaned out to look.

The ever-thickening fog had already covered every street. The heavy fog and the clouds high above hung over Frostholm like layer upon layer of a Veil. Within that heavy Veil, the daylight had already dimmed to dusk. In the distance, they could not even see the stores on the far side of the main street.

But there was still a patch of light in the sky. That was where the Sun was.

It was clearly daytime. It was clearly Vision 001.

“Nina, look.” Shirley raised her hand and pointed at the sky. “The Sun is right there…”

She suddenly stopped.

Deep inside the thick fog and cloud, that bright patch of light trembled a few times. Then, like a reflection on water, it spread outward and blurred.

It seemed that from the very start, that had not been the Sun at all. It was only a visual afterimage left above the city when the Veil had risen.

Above Frostholm, the Sun vanished.

…

At the same time, in the center of the city-state, deep under the ground right beneath the Boiling Gold mine, lay the ancient, sealed Second Waterway.

The fog in the city had not spread down here. The small changes on the surface did not affect the exploration teams. In this deep, abandoned underground world, the Church’s Guardian troops were busy and orderly as they strengthened the forward base they had just built.

Spider-like Steam Walkers slid through the wide sewer corridors. Their high-powered searchlights swept over every dark corner. The multi-barrel guns on the turrets at the “spiders’” sides shifted their aim by small degrees, ready for any Shadows that might lurk in the side tunnels. Silent Monks in black robes sat behind cover at the crossroads, praying in silence as they rested and gathered strength for the next push. Veteran elite Guardians held the posts and doors at each junction. consecrated lanterns hung at their belts. One hand held a Gatekeeper’s cane. The other gripped a specially modified shotgun or a large-caliber revolver.

Darkness had ruled the Second Waterway for far too long. Working here in this dim place was less an “investigation” and more a declaration of war on a twisted, monstrous kingdom.

The enemy could be anything. The enemy was the darkness itself.

A strange hissing came from a branch corridor in the distance, mixed with the sound of some huge limbs crawling and writhing. Two Steam Walkers stood guard at the junction. They reacted at once. Four powerful flash grenades shot from the front of the spider machines first. Right after that, the Guardians on the walkers swung the rotary guns toward the source of the sound and opened fire in a sweeping burst. In the deafening thunder, that patch of darkness swelled sharply. It seemed something inside had been hurt and was about to show itself.

Twelve Silent Monks in black robes stood up from behind their cover. As one, they raised the Sacred Tomes in their hands. Their bandaged arms stretched out toward the darkness, and they let out a fierce shout.

Pale flames burst out in the dark. Together with the barrage from the Steam Walkers, they burned whatever the formless darkness had been breeding into ash.

The restless darkness fell quiet again. The branch corridor slowly went from pitch-black to dim, then from dim to bright. The lamps pushed their normal light forward to reach the junction and showed what was there.

There was nothing. Only pits and craters of all sizes in the walls.

And a faint, foul smell in the air that quickly faded.

Agatha drew back her gaze from the distant junction.

One branch had been reclaimed. The Guardian troops had driven back another patch of darkness in this underground world. Yet in the vast Second Waterway, this was only a tiny corner.

She was not here to deal with those “junctions.”

“Take me to that door.”

The Gatekeeper turned her head a little and spoke to the subordinate at her side.

Chapter 403: The Depleted Truth

Leading a small team of fully armed Guardians, Agatha left the forward base that the Church troops had built. They passed through several makeshift fences made from simple works and firing positions. Then they went through a junction lit by gas lamps and finally reached the far end of a side corridor.

The gas lamps set into the walls gave off a soft hiss. The old pipe system fed them unevenly, so their light flickered and dimmed. In that unsteady light, they could see a thick, black alloy gate standing silently at the end of the hall.

The sound of the Gatekeeper’s cane and her heels striking the floor echoed hollowly along the corridor. Agatha stopped before the gate. Maybe too much time had passed, because the seal on this door had already failed. There was a narrow gap between the two leaves. The lead seal that had once hung on the latch looked as if it had suffered some unknown impact. Clear stretch and tear marks showed in the middle.

On a plaque at the side of the door, they could see the steel stamp of Frostholm City Hall.

This was what the explorers had found in these depths. It was the strange door in the center of the Second Waterway that she had told Governor Winston about.

City Hall had sealed this place, yet the governor himself knew nothing about the door. All records about it had vanished. It might date back to the

chaotic years just after the end of the Queen’s age. The turmoil of that time had let the door and the secret behind it slip out of people’s memories.

Was this the nest where the Annihilators hid? Or was it the riddle that Frostholm’s Queen Ray Nora had left for the world?

Agatha reached out and gently touched the rough, heavy alloy panel. For some reason, her fingertips felt dull and numb. Only the chill under her skin was sharply clear.

“Are we opening this door?” A black-clad guard stepped forward half a pace. “The governor’s permission has already come down…”

“Mr. Winston did give permission, but you can’t just throw open a door that has sat sealed in the dark for years,” Agatha said, shaking her head slightly. “There might be something dangerous locked behind it. I will go over first and check the situation.”

The nearby Guardians understood their commander at once and stepped back.

Agatha lifted her head and looked at the crack between the two leaves. Then she reached forward.

Nothing happened. She frowned in puzzlement.

A black-clad guard glanced over with curiosity. “Is something wrong?”

“…No. Nothing.” Agatha shook her head, then focused again.

At last, a gust of wind stirred in the open space. Her figure turned into a swirl of gray-white mist. The Ashen Wind circled twice before the gate, then slipped into the narrow gap.

“Hold position and keep watch. Wait for the Gatekeeper to return.”

The captain of the black-clad guards let out a quiet breath when he saw Agatha pass through the door. Then he began ordering the squad members to set up firing positions along the corridor.

On the far side, the gray-white whirl of wind passed through the gap and entered a dim space. The wind spun for a moment, and Agatha's body took shape again out of it.

The Gatekeeper looked back at the gate she had come through, then lowered her head to check herself. She frowned without thinking.

Why did the divine magic she used every day feel so stiff today? Even her body's own response seemed a bit slower.

After a moment of confusion, Agatha shook her head and pushed her attention back to the task at hand.

She looked around. The consecrated lantern at her waist cast a dim yellow glow that drove back the darkness around her. It seemed many restless things were hiding in the shadows on all sides, but when she focused her will, the dark quieted again.

She stood in a damp, gloomy passage. Bare earth and stones with a metallic sheen showed everywhere. In the weak light of the consecrated lantern she could also see the beams and supports that held up the tunnel, and some scattered odds and ends lying by piles of rock.

Agatha frowned. This did not look like any part of the Second Waterway. A normal sewer corridor did not have this structure. The space behind this gate… looked more like a mine tunnel that had been abandoned for a long time.

A mine tunnel?

Agatha lifted her head and stared thoughtfully at the damp, dark rock ceiling above. Her gaze seemed to go straight through the thick rock and

earth, up and up through layers of passages, shafts, machines, and ramps.

The Boiling Gold mine.

This section of the Second Waterway lay under the center of the city-state. Its underground branches crisscrossed around the Boiling Gold mine. Quite a few sewer lines had even been part of the mine's drainage system in the Queen's era. In some of these, the distance between sewer and mine tunnel really might be only a single door.

She walked slowly along the tunnel, and more and more questions rose in her mind.

This was only a mine tunnel. It did not even seem fully swallowed and twisted by darkness yet. Boiling Gold itself was a holy metal. The tiny traces of Boiling Gold in the rock and soil were enough to resist corruption, like lamps and steam. Why, then, had they gone to such lengths to seal a tunnel like this behind a grand door?

It was locked away underground. Even the current governor did not know it existed. If the order to seal it had really come from the first City Hall after the Queen's age, then what was so special about this place that it had made them so nervous?

And this tunnel had clearly been abandoned. Why? It plainly had not been corrupted. There were no monsters here, no illusions, and no…

Boiling Gold.

Agatha suddenly stopped. Her eyes swept over the working levels dug into the sides of the tunnel. At last she began to understand the source of the wrongness she had felt all along.

There was no Boiling Gold here.

…

At City Hall, on the top floor of the old Queen’s palace, in a domed office, the plump governor Winston, dressed in a blue coat, slowly toyed with a delicate machine in his hands.

The brass model made a soft clicking in his grip. Gears and linkages turned. Every bite and rotation carried a cold, precise beauty.

A creation of wisdom. A crystallization of engineering. A fruit of civilization. The turning of gears was the medal and ribbon of mortal civilization.

Winston set the model down in front of him. He casually used the decorative ribbon on his coat to wipe a smear of oil near the base. After cleaning it off, he nodded slightly, his face full of quiet delight, like a man admiring a work of art.

“Boiling Gold is Frostholm’s blood. The mining machines are the hearts that pump that blood…”

Winston muttered softly as he flicked the tiny brass gears with his fingers. It sounded half like talking to himself and half like speaking to the little machine.

“Fifty years… like a dream, gone in a blink…”

He slowly rose and paced over to the window.

Outside the wide glass panes, thick fog filled the whole city. In the swirling mist, every building and street blurred at the edges, as if they were about to melt into the city itself. Even the lofty Cathedral across the plaza became only a vague shadow in the fog. The many towers and spires looked like giants choking and dying in the haze.

Winston looked calmly at the fog outside the window. He could hear the alarm bells from across the plaza. He could also hear the Guard Corps of

City Hall and the Constable units gathering and taking orders on the square below.

Fog this heavy and this strange was bound to draw City Hall's attention. Even without an order from the governor, the city's Guard forces would follow their set procedures and move first. But keeping order in the fog might turn out to be the easiest part of what came next.

Winston stood at the window for a while, then turned toward a spot not far away.

A small round table stood near the window. Thin strands of fog seeped through the cracks and drifted around it. In the smoke-like haze, he saw two things lying on the tabletop.

One was a stack of papers, already yellowed and brittle. The other was a finely made revolver.

The documents were written and prepared in an old formal style. The edges of the fine paper had ornate printed patterns, carrying that special elegance of the Queen's era.

"Boiling Gold Mine Exhaustion Warning." "Investigation Report on the Anomaly Shaft." "Analysis of the Extracted Ore Samples"…

Most of the signatures and dates on the files ran from 1840 to 1845.

The reader and signer at the bottom was Ray Nora.

The revolver was Governor Winston's personal collection, a classic model from twelve years ago. It was still solid and reliable even now. Its well-kept grip and frame shone with oil. It looked as if it could serve another twelve years—or longer.

Winston's gaze moved off the papers and came to rest on the revolver.

He reached out and picked up the heavy steel, feeling its cold weight. He opened the cylinder to check the rounds, then snapped it shut.

His right hand slowly rose. The barrel, once carefully maintained by a Master, pressed against his temple.

A few seconds later, he lowered the gun.

“This pose is not bad. I’ll use this pose when the time comes,” Winston said softly. Then he checked the safety and slid the revolver neatly into the holster at his waist.

Hurried footsteps sounded in the corridor.

“Governor, the fog in the city is getting worse…”

“I know. I’m coming.”

Chapter 404: Crossing

In the damp, chilly corridor of the Second Waterway, the Gatekeeper walked toward the deeper darkness.

The black uniform that represented the city's defenders was already in tatters. The combat Gatekeeper's cane, made with special techniques, was covered in scars. Pain and exhaustion felt like some distant illusion. In her ears there was only the hollow echo from the depths below.

Her blood seemed almost drained, but her heart still beat. Death was so close that she felt the chill of the world of The dead with every breath. In this dark, lonely corridor there were no more Comrades. She had not seen an enemy for a long time.

But something still accompanied Agatha on this road to death: a small flame that was not very bright, but carried a bit of warmth.

Agatha held her left hand to her chest, carefully guarding that cluster of flame that flickered out of thin air, the Fire Seed. The ghostly green fire lit her chin and a short stretch of the corridor around her. She felt, even savored, the little warmth the Fire Seed gave her, because she could feel that the road ahead was growing even colder.

Or perhaps, it was her own body that was growing cold.

Agatha spoke softly to the flame: "I have already passed the Upper City junction and am getting close to the side corridors near the Boiling Gold mine…"

She lifted her head and glanced at a plaque on the wall ahead. The mottled, old metal plate listed the streets of the district above this section of sewer, helping her confirm where she was.

“This whole stretch, I have met almost no enemies, but the road is getting harder to walk,” she went on quietly. “There is a kind of… suffocating cold that is slowing my steps.”

A deep, commanding voice sounded directly in her heart: “Perhaps those cultists have given up using their minions to slow your steps… They are putting all their effort into the final moment.”

“How are things outside?”

“A heavy fog has risen. It covers the entire city. The city’s Guard Corps is keeping order and urging residents to go home. Guardian squads can already be seen at some intersections. They are carrying consecrated lanterns for night patrols, because the thick fog is blocking the power of the Sun,” the commanding voice in Agatha’s heart said. “Fog is rising over the sea around the city as well. It may stretch for more than a hundred nautical miles.”

“…Those Heretics have made their move,” Agatha said softly. “Maybe my actions pushed them, made them act ahead of time…”

“You do not seem to be in good shape.”

“I may be badly hurt,” Agatha kept walking. Her breathing felt heavy, yet her mind was clearer than ever. “But you do not need to worry about me. I am ready to die. I will carry your Fire Seed into their lair, no matter how.”

“I would much rather watch you finish this mission alive, Agatha. Even if you are an Envoy of the God of Death, there is no need to rush to report to Bartok. By the way, that makes me curious. For you priests of the God of Death, is ‘death’… considered a demotion or a promotion?”

Agatha froze for a moment, then tugged at the corner of her mouth: “Your sense of humor really surprised me. Sorry, I truly cannot answer that. I am afraid all the priests of Death since ancient times have never thought about it. If I get the chance… I will think about it carefully.”

“Good. I hope you find the answer.”

The voice in her mind fell silent for now. Agatha let out a soft breath. She did not know if it was an illusion, but suddenly her breathing did not feel as labored as before, and even her steps became a little lighter.

She glanced at the Fire Seed cradled in her left hand, carefully shielded it, and stepped past another junction.

Water overflowed from a nearby drain and formed a small puddle on the ground. The surface was still as a mirror, reflecting the dim dome above the waterway.

Agatha stepped through the puddle. The calm surface rippled in layers, and in the suddenly shattered reflection there appeared a figure in a black trench coat, body wrapped in ritual bandages, holding a tin Gatekeeper’s cane.

That figure walked toward the direction Agatha had come from. In that brief instant, they passed each other.

…

Agatha suddenly stopped and looked back in some confusion at the place she had just walked past. She saw the small patch of standing water there. The surface, disturbed by footsteps, still rippled in layers.

In the disturbed, broken water she could no longer see the reflection from a moment ago, yet Agatha could not shake the feeling that she had just seen something.

It was a figure, somewhat like herself, yet not quite the same. That figure wore a ragged black uniform, body covered in wounds, as if it had gone through battle after battle, and it had been walking toward the deeper part of the Second Waterway.

That was exactly the place she had just left.

She must have stopped a bit too suddenly, because a subordinate's voice came from behind her: "Gatekeeper? What happened?"

"That puddle…" Agatha turned back and pointed not far away. "Was it already there just now? Did any of you see anything strange in it?"

"The puddle?" The subordinate looked back at it, face full of doubt. "It was there just now… but I did not see anything strange."

Agatha said nothing. She fell silent, fixing her gaze on the still-shaking surface of the water for a long time. Only after a while did a trace of solemn thought slowly appear in her eyes.

"Did you see something?" The subordinate could not help sounding a bit worried.

Agatha stayed silent for a moment more before she shook her head lightly: "Do not worry. Everything is fine. Everything… is fine."

The subordinate was still clearly puzzled, but when he saw his superior's solemn expression, he held back his curiosity and quickly changed the topic: "What did you find on the other side of that door just now? You have looked very serious ever since you came back…"

Agatha quickly gathered her scattered thoughts. She lifted her head and looked toward the way she had come. The large door leading to the abandoned mine tunnel had already vanished beyond the junction, but she still clearly remembered what she had found in that dark tunnel.

She had not explored that tunnel for long. After confirming her discovery, she had returned to the Second Waterway the way she came and hurriedly led her team back toward the stronghold. Out of necessary caution, she still had not told her subordinates what she had actually found behind that door.

Even now, she did not know how to explain that shocking and bizarre… "guess" to the black-clothed Guards before her.

After a brief hesitation, she turned and continued walking toward the stronghold.

After they had walked some distance, she suddenly spoke softly, almost as if talking to herself: "Frostholm… what does it use to sustain its existence?"

"What does it use to sustain its existence?" The subordinate was stunned for a moment and did not react right away. After a few seconds he spoke hesitantly: "You mean… the city's economic base? The Boiling Gold business?"

"Boiling Gold is Frostholm's blood. The mine is the city's heart…" Agatha murmured to herself, saying things that only confused the black-clothed Guards. "It seems none of us ever thought about the day when this heart might stop beating…"

Another black-clothed Guard could not help stepping forward, a hint of tension on his face: "You…"

Agatha raised her hand lightly and cut him off.

"Do not think too much yet. Nothing is certain. I did see some things on the other side of that door, but whether I can tell you about them will depend on my discussion with the Archbishop."

She had already calmed down from her earlier unease.

Maybe she had been too nervous. It was only a dried-up, abandoned mine tunnel. For an old mine that had been worked for so many years, it was not surprising for one or two tunnels to run dry. The later decision by City Hall to seal it off was very likely for another reason. Some kind of corruption that had once existed there but had now faded was the most likely explanation.

Jumping to conclusions was a great taboo in any investigation.

Agatha shook her head, yet the brief scene she had just seen in that puddle rose again in her mind.

That battle-worn, bloodstained “self” walking the opposite way in the reflection.

Agatha closed her eyes a little. Her fingers tightened around the Gatekeeper’s cane until the knuckles turned a bit white. But a moment later she opened her eyes again and looked ahead. Her face had already returned to calm.

She still had many things to do.

In silence, Agatha led the Guardian squad back to the stronghold at the underground crossroads, and as soon as she returned, she sensed that something in the atmosphere there was off.

A faintly tense air hung over the stronghold. A priest who looked as if he had just come up from the shaft was talking nervously with the officer in charge of the stronghold’s defense. Several steam walkers that had gone out earlier to clear the side passages had been called back early and now seemed ready to take the shaft lift back to the surface.

Agatha stepped forward quickly, and before she could even ask, the black-clothed Guard commander in charge of this stronghold spoke in haste: “Honored Gatekeeper, something has happened on the surface.”

Agatha frowned: “What is it?”

“Fog. A huge, eerie fog. It covers the whole city and the nearby sea. You cannot even see the Sun in the sky,” the commander reported quickly. “And Malevolent Spirits have appeared in the library and the archives. The scholars on duty managed to suppress them in time, but fear and chaos are spreading through the city. The Archbishop has sent people down to ask you to return at once!”

Chapter 405: Impact and Awakening

Fog was everywhere. The whole world seemed to have sunk into a deep pool of gray-white fluid. Everything in sight had its edges blurred by the mist. The distant city, the nearby roads… all became vague and unclear.

After moving underground for only a short time, the scene on the surface had become something she no longer recognized.

Agatha, who had hurried back to the surface from the Second Waterway, stood at the exit of the transit station and stared in shock at the street. There were no pedestrians on the road at all now. Under the thick fog, even the nearby streetlights were reduced to hazy clusters of glow floating in midair. Besides that, she could only see some dark red lights slowly moving in the mist, mixed with the sound of steam engines at work—warning lights on top of steam walkers, flashing as they moved.

“The city’s Guard Corps and constable units have rushed to every major intersection. Movement between districts is now strictly forbidden. All civilian vehicles are banned from the roads. citizens who could not get home in time are being directed to the nearest shelters,” a Church priest who had come to meet Agatha reported. “Most veil of night Sanctuary Worlds are already full. We can only work with the security forces to divert people into the Cathedral, warehouses, and the nearest subway stations.”

At this point, the priest paused and let out a heavy sigh.

“Sigh… We could have sent more people to places like the library to take shelter, but corruption has started appearing wherever large numbers of books are stored. All the book repositories have been sealed off. The fog rose right when most factories in the city were changing shifts. Too many people were far from home.”

Agatha did not answer. She slowly drew her gaze back from the street and raised her head in thought to look at the sky.

Heavy clouds and the city’s own mist hid the sky. The daylight was as dim as dusk, and in that murky vault she could not see the trace of the Sun.

“It is daytime now…” she said softly.

“Yes, it is daytime, but this strange fog may be interfering with the power of the Sun,” the priest said, face grim and a bit tense. “The corruption that appeared in the library is because of this…”

“Nothing can interfere with the power of the Sun during the day. As long as Vision 001 hangs in the sky, even if clouds block the sunlight and plunge the whole city into a veil of night, the power of the Sun will not weaken,” Agatha shook her head slightly. “In my judgment, this thick fog is not the cause. It is probably only a ‘phenomenon’ triggered by a greater crisis. How are things on the mountain?”

“The great Cathedral is packed with people now,” the priest said quickly. At the same time, several steam walkers with their warning lights on clanked onto the open ground near the transit station exit. Between the walkers was a car bearing the Church’s flag. “Your car is here. Let us go back to the mountain first. We can talk on the way.”

Agatha and the priest climbed into the car. The steam walkers cast strong beams of light into the fog. On the barely lit road, the vehicle set off toward

the great Cathedral at the mountaintop, moving much more slowly than usual.

“When the fog rose, many worshippers and tourists were still on the mountain. The great Cathedral sheltered as many as it could. Those it truly could not take in were sent to the old Cathedral next door, the City Museum. City Hall has also arranged Sanctuary Worlds, so at least people were not left outside,” the priest went on reporting to Agatha in the car. “Archbishop Ivan has now stabilized the situation and has not let panic spread inside the Cathedral. Since just now he has been using Psychic Communication to stay in contact with Cathedrals all over the city. So far, no corruption caused by mass panic has appeared…”

A deep mechanical rumble sounded outside the car window. Agatha turned her head toward the direction of the noise.

She saw several long aerial tracks stretching out from above the mountain road, cutting through the thick fog and pointing into the distance. Tall support towers held up the tracks like giants. A black cargo cabin hung from one of the tracks, roaring as it moved into the depths of the mist. The red warning lights around the cabin were like many eyes, blinking nonstop in the fog.

This was the transport system of the Boiling Gold mine. The raw Boiling Gold ore dug out of the mine was carried in those huge cargo cabins along the mountain tracks to the crushing and sorting plants and the great Crucible at the foot of the mountain.

“…The mine tracks are still running?” Agatha turned back in surprise and looked at the priest beside her. “Have the workers not gone to take shelter?”

At the same time, the scene she had just seen deep underground rose in her mind: that ancient mine tunnel that had already run dry decades ago.

“The workers must have gone to take shelter,” the priest said. He looked just as surprised when he saw the cargo cabin on the track, but he still answered with certainty. “The mine Cathedral has already confirmed it. What you see going by now is probably the last batch of ore sent from the tunneling area. It should have been arranged automatically by the Sorting Engine—you know, the Boiling Gold ore that has been mined only stays in the storage yard for a while before it is sent off. It is all set on the program’s punched paper tape. The machines only follow the instruc—”

A disturbing roar suddenly came from the other side of the fog, cutting off the priest’s confident words. Everyone instantly looked toward the source of the sound, but all they saw was another black cargo cabin rushing along the aerial track from the other end—the same track the first cabin had just passed over the mountain road on.

“They are going to crash!!”

The priest only had time to cry out once before the earth-shaking collision happened. The two cargo trains slammed into each other on the aerial track with a terrifying roar and explosion. The side panels of the cabins were torn open, and ore that glowed pale gold poured down the hillside like a rainstorm. Then, as the two cargo trains rocked and swung violently on the track, their drive wheels and guide wheels fell off, axles snapped, and the twisted cabins, spitting sparks and thick smoke, tumbled down into the valley.

A chunk of falling debris from the sky almost scraped the roof of the car Agatha rode in before it smashed hard into the roadside.

Before anyone in the car could react, another teeth-grinding, dreadful sound of metal tearing came again from high above.

The aerial track that had taken the violent impact twisted and warped. Sparks burst from the top of one of the iron towers supporting it. Stretched

steel beams and cables snapped with loud cracks, and then an entire section of the track came crashing down from above!

“Get out of the way!”

The priest in the car shouted at once, but even before he spoke, the convoy had already begun to dodge the fallen relic falling from the sky. Several steam walkers scattered at once, and the steam car in the middle of the formation suddenly surged forward. After a few heart-stopping seconds, a terrifying crash sounded from behind Agatha.

She looked back and saw that the broken section of track had already crashed onto the mountain road, completely destroying the main route. Two steam walkers were trapped on the far side of the fallen relic, but thankfully they were unharmed. They moved their long mechanical legs and began to climb the nearby slope instead. White high-pressure steam spurted from the gaps in their armor plates and merged with the surrounding fog.

“Walkers Two and Four cannot get through. They are probably going to climb up to the upper path and circle back to the great Cathedral. We do not need to wait for them,” Agatha said after a quick glance back, making her judgment and giving the order. “Keep going.”

“That was far too close…” The priest beside her could not help wiping the cold sweat from his forehead. “It almost came down right on our heads.”

Agatha did not speak for a moment.

Had that been an accident? Or… malice?

Why would a mine track that should only carry one-way, single-line traffic suddenly have a cargo cabin coming from the opposite direction?

By now the mine’s workers should all have gone to the shelters. In theory, the operator of the track system would also leave after setting up the last train. The final step of attaching a cargo cabin to the track had a safety lock.

If there was already another cabin on the line, it would never depart. A Sorting Engine controlled this entire process, and a properly running Sorting Engine did not make mistakes. Its gears and levers faithfully carried out the program set on the punched paper tape. There was no room for doubt in the mesh of metal.

“The mine’s Sorting Engine may have gone wrong…” Agatha murmured, almost to herself.

And the mine’s Sorting Engine might not be the only thing that had gone wrong. If Malevolent Spirit corruption could appear in the library in broad daylight, then the scope and urgency of this mutation was beyond anything anyone had imagined.

…

Faint police bells from distant streets drifted into his ears. A chaotic, disordered cold wind swept freely through the empty graveyard. Thick fog shrouded everything in sight, and in that unbroken mist it seemed as if countless low whispers overlapped and echoed, like the restless stirring of The dead.

The click of a safety catch being released broke the graveyard’s silence. The faint glow of a consecrated lantern pushed back the Shadows in the fog. A hunched old man gripped his loyal, dependable double-barreled shotgun and stood on the path like a watchful sentry, staring hard at the rows of coffins lined up in the mist.

The whispers were only an illusion—for now, at least. Those coffins still rested honestly on the platforms, and the people in them still lay there honestly. Yet the strange feeling in the air could not fool a veteran’s senses.

He knew something was happening. This graveyard was absolutely not going to stay quiet today. Among the “guests” he “looked after” here, some

were slowly waking up.

Chapter 406: Gunfire in the Graveyard

In the graveyard, the Old Caretaker raised his head again and glanced at the Warden’s hut beside him.

He had already reported the restlessness among the dead in the mortuary as an express dispatch to the Cathedral, but there was still no reply—clearly, with the whole city shrouded in strange fog and the sunlight in the sky unnaturally gone, the Cathedral no longer had the spare attention to care about an Anomaly in a small graveyard.

“We can only count on ourselves now…” the Old Caretaker muttered, pulling his coat tighter. The leather armor and metal plates sewn into the lining gave a faint scraping sound. “This fog covers quite a distance…”

The clatter and scraping broke the deathly silence of the graveyard. Under the thick fog, several coffins on nearby platforms seemed to give a faint shudder.

“Considering I stand night watch over you lot every day, you cannot behave yourselves at a time like this?” The Old Caretaker frowned and lifted the barrel of his gun a little. He knew these bodies, laid out properly for days, were suddenly “moving” because of this strange fog, but there was nothing he could do.

He could only wait for them to climb out and then send them off one by one with a shot.

As this thought ran through his mind, a sound different from the restless noise inside the coffins suddenly caught his attention. He froze for a second, then reacted at once and looked toward the path at the graveyard gate.

A small figure stumbled out from the far end of the path. In the dimness, the white coat and skirt looked like a bouncing snowball.

“Grandpa Caretaker! Help me! Grandpa Caretaker! Are you there?!”

The little “snowball” shouted as she ran along the path. Her voice sounded strained, as if she was trying hard to press down her fear and panic.

“Annie!” The Old Caretaker forgot his shock at once and called through the fog to the girl: “Come here! Do not go that way!”

The flustered girl running into the graveyard finally saw the old man standing near the Warden’s hut. For a moment, the fear on her face eased, and she ran toward him at once: “Grandpa Caretaker! I am so glad you are here…”

“Why are you still running around outside at a time like this?!” The Old Caretaker did not bother listening to her joy. He set his face and scolded loudly. Today was not like other days. The danger in this fog was nothing like slippery streets in a snowfall. “Do you know the whole city is under lockdown now?!”

“I got separated from my classmates!” Annie was startled by the old man’s stern face and tone, but she still waved her hands and explained quickly: “We went with Teacher to visit the City Museum. When we came out, we ran into the thick fog. Teacher said to take us to the nearest veil of night shelter, but in the blink of an eye Teacher and the others walked into the fog and were gone…”

The Warden stared wide-eyed: “They walked into the fog and disappeared?”

“Yes, gone, just like that, in a blink,” Annie still looked badly shaken, but she tried her best to explain what had happened. “Then I went to find a place to hide by myself. The City Museum was sealed off. I could not find any Lords on the streets. All the doors were locked. I knocked as hard as I could but no one opened up. Then I remembered Teacher said that if we ran into danger, we should go to the nearest priest, Guardian, or constable. The graveyard is the closest, and I heard you say you are a veteran Guardian…”

As he listened to the girl’s rapid-fire explanation, the Old Caretaker’s expression shifted several times. He realized that, in his panic, he had wrongly blamed the young lady. For someone her age, this child had actually handled things quite calmly. But he could not bring himself to admit it, so he kept his face stiff: “So you came to the graveyard to take shelter?”

Annie nodded hard: “Yes. Everyone says veteran Guardians are stronger than normal Guardians…”

“…But a graveyard is not a good place to take shelter,” the Old Caretaker said in a low voice. “Especially at a time like this.”

Annie looked flustered: “I… I should not have come here?”

“…No. There is no better choice now. If you ran around the streets in this fog, it would be even more dangerous,” the Old Caretaker shook his head. “You hide first—”

Before he could finish, a strange rattling noise nearby cut him off. Out of the corner of his eye, he saw a shadow rise suddenly from the nearest platform. The lid of a cheap coffin was shoved open. A restless arm struggled up from inside, and then the restless dead sat up!

He did not even have time to tell Annie to close her eyes. The Old Caretaker raised his double-barreled shotgun by instinct. With a thunderous bang, the

corpse that had just staggered upright fell on its back and rolled off the platform to the ground.

“Ah!”

Annie, hiding behind him, was still only a child. The gunshot made her jump, but more than the gunshot, she was shocked by that corpse that had just sat up in the fog.

“That… that…” The little girl pointed in terror at the platform from before, stammering.

The Old Caretaker started to speak without thinking: “Do not be afraid, that is just—”

“supernatural, volume three, chapter six talked about this!” Annie finally caught her breath and shouted quickly: “Teacher said that in times like this we should at once silently repeat Bartok’s name in our hearts, then use a rosewood branch or a smoke-cured rope to lash the Restless One, and then look for a chance to run to the nearest Cathedral for help…”

The Old Caretaker stared blankly as he listened to the girl’s rapid words. After two or three seconds, he suddenly snapped back, snapped another shell into the shotgun, and turned without looking back to aim at another platform. With another thunderous bang, another Restless One that had just crawled out of its coffin lay back down where it should have slept.

“Your textbooks are different from ours. Back then we only covered that lesson in high school,” he said offhandedly.

Annie hugged her head without thinking. Her small body shook from the shock of the second gunshot. She had recited the textbook fast just now, but her fear and nervousness still showed plainly.

“You hide inside the house,” the old man said. He shielded the girl and brought her to the Warden’s hut. He reached back to open the door and

pushed Annie in: “No matter what happens outside, you must not leave. As long as you do not go out, this little hut is as safe as the icon hall in the Cathedral. Do you understand?”

Annie’s eyes opened wide with fear. She kept nodding as she stared at the fog outside. In her sight, the platforms in the fog seemed to come alive one after another. Shadows writhed between them. Invisible howls echoed across the graveyard. Coffins nailed shut split and burst open one after another, and terrifying figures were waking and sitting up from those “beds” that should have been for peaceful rest.

The Old Caretaker pushed Annie farther into the hut, shut the door, then turned and fired again.

The Warden’s hut was sturdy, and wards protected it. But if every dead body in the graveyard really climbed out, then this thin, small Sanctuary World might not hold off all their attacks. Even if it held up physically, the mental shock of the dead besieging it could still pierce the hut’s protection and affect the child.

The more he put down now, the safer Annie would be.

“By the God of Death, I have been retired for ten years!”

The veteran let out a rough growl from his throat. His hands worked the action with practiced ease, throwing out the spent shells and feeding in fresh rounds. In his already cloudy eyes, a fire seemed to burn. He needed almost no aim at all before he had the next unruly “resident” in his sights.

The gun roared. The dead rested. Smoke rose, and souls passed on.

“The Gatekeepers on the ‘other side’ will be busy today. I hope they can handle so many souls setting off early.”

The Old Caretaker muttered to himself, but his hands never stopped. Several Restless Ones had already started moving toward the Warden’s hut.

He loaded round after round, fired shot after shot, sending his “tenants” on their way ahead of time.

More and more staggering corpses appeared around the path.

Those vague, flickering shapes even left the Old Caretaker briefly confused —

Were there really this many bodies in the graveyard? Even if you added up every platform, could they hold so many corpses?

Were they appearing out of this fog out of thin air?!

Bang!

After another gunshot, the Old Caretaker heard a snarl very close by. Without even lifting his head, his left hand slid to his chest, and a short sword appeared in his grip. In the next second, his body seemed to vanish and reappear a few meters away beside the door. The short sword flashed through the air. A corpse fell, and a swollen, twisted head rolled across the ground.

The old man looked down. On that head, there was only one huge eye.

His shock lasted only for a moment. Then he was back at the hut door, raising his gun and aiming at another shadow that was lurching toward him through the fog.

He pulled the trigger, but the gun did not fire. Only the empty click of the hammer sounded.

His eyes changed slightly. He sheathed the short sword at once and reached to the cartridge pouch at his waist with his free hand—it was already empty.

After a brief silence, the Old Caretaker sighed: “That is fine. The numbers are about right…”

He lowered the empty shotgun, drew his short sword again, and looked up at the shapes that were wobbling out of the fog one by one.

A faint creak came from behind him.

The Warden’s hut was being opened from the inside.

The old man turned in surprise and saw Annie peeking out at him.

The young lady clutched a loaded large-caliber rifle in her hands—that was his spare weapon.

At the girl’s feet lay several cartridge pouches and ammo boxes of all sizes.

Scratches showed clearly on the floor. Annie had clearly dragged all that heavy stuff over from the corner with great effort.

“Grandpa Caretaker, use this,” Annie said. She lifted the rifle and handed it to the old man with some effort. “Will it help?”

“…Yes.” After a short silence, the old man nodded, took the rifle, and tossed the double-barreled shotgun to the girl: “Load it.”

Chapter 407: The Curtain Rises

The nonstop thunder of gunfire had already shattered the quiet of Graveyard No. 3. Flames bursting from the muzzle lit the dim fog again and again. Twisted, swaying figures kept emerging from the mist, only to fall one by one under the holy blast of fire and metal—and in the spots where they fell, black, ominous matter was already spreading across the path.

These were clearly no longer just “restless corpses”. They were something more profane and more ominous, and they had to be wiped out here.

The old man’s aim was very good. The deformed things walking out of the fog looked to him like slow-moving insects. Even through the thick mist, he could pick them off one by one.

In truth, he was even better with his short sword and his Gatekeeper’s cane, and had far more experience with them. But the old man knew he had to avoid close combat with the monsters for as long as possible.

He was already very old. A veteran’s experience could not make up for an aging body, and the enemy seemed endless. Once he was caught in hand-to-hand fighting, he would no longer be able to keep the monsters on the far side of the path.

He had to calculate exactly, to kill as many monsters as possible with as little strength as he could, and to buy time. The Cathedral and the city’s authority had to be taking action. Reinforcements would come, from one side or another. This city would not fall in some inexplicable fog like this.

Faintly, other gunshots sounded in the distance.

“Grandpa Caretaker!” Annie cried, handing him the freshly loaded rifle again. She glanced nervously toward the direction of the distant shots. “They are shooting in other places too… is someone coming to help us?”

“That is the Wardens from Graveyard No. 4 and No. 2.” The old man raised his gun and blew apart an ugly head that had appeared in the fog, speaking without looking back: “People will come to help us. Do not be afraid.”

“I am not afraid.” Annie tried to say it loudly, though her voice trembled a bit. The graveyard’s Old Caretaker did not call out the brave front she was putting up.

Because she was already brave enough.

“You really are brave,” the Old Caretaker said. He tried to sound relaxed, even though his arms had already started to shake. “Where did you learn all this? How do you know how to load rifles and shotguns?”

“My Mother has several guns. She hangs them in the bedroom and in the sitting room,” Annie said as she quickly pressed shells into the shotgun’s tube magazine. “The year Dad did not come back, Mother bought a bunch of guns. Mother said she needed to protect the house… ah!”

The spring on the latch of the magazine suddenly snapped open. The sharp metal edge sliced a long cut on the young lady’s finger, and she cried out.

But in the next second, she used another finger to push the spring back into place and handed the loaded shotgun to the old man in front of her: “Here you are.”

The Old Caretaker noticed the blood on the gun and heard Annie’s cry, but after a moment of silence he only tossed another gun behind him: “…Load it.”

The gunfire thundered again.

The black-clad old man, bent with age, stood like a crooked yet stubborn tree, nailed in place amid the dense fog. He and Annie slowly stopped talking. Only silent gunfire remained, and his expression grew more and more grave. He was counting—how many monsters he had already put down, and how many times Annie had handed him a loaded shotgun or rifle.

“Last box of bullets,” he muttered under his breath.

“Grandpa Caretaker, this is the last box of bullets!” Annie cried out almost at the same time.

“I know.” The Old Caretaker did not look back. He silently took down a twisted freak that had almost reached the hut, then beckoned behind him: “Load the shotgun, then put the gun and the rest of the bullets by my feet. You go to my bed. Under it there is a dark brown chest. Inside is spare ammunition.”

“Okay! Dark brown chest, spare ammunition!” Annie answered at once. She pushed the gun and bullets out the door and ran back inside.

The Old Caretaker looked down quietly at the shotgun and bullets at his feet. Then he turned slightly, closed the door with one hand, and drew the short sword from his chest, driving it hard through the outer latch.

Almost at once, he heard hurried footsteps inside the hut, then the sound of the girl pounding on the door and crying out.

“…This is the last time I trick you.”

The Old Caretaker said it softly, then, holding the gun in one hand, fired in quick bursts at the twisted freaks closest to him. He spun around, kicked off the doorframe, and leaped up. His free left hand swept across a corner above the frame, and a pitch-black Gatekeeper’s cane appeared in his grip. Before he landed, he brought the black staff down hard on another monster

rising from the fog. As that head shattered and the corpse hit the ground, he landed as well, steady on his feet.

His gaze swept the dense fog before him. The old man swung the black staff hard. Filthy black fluid, like mutated blood, flew from its surface. Then he slammed the Gatekeeper's cane onto the ground. Metal mechanisms clicked. The black shaft shortened by half an inch, and countless sharp blades sprang out from its sides.

When the blades sprang open, it seemed as if countless layered cries and roars from the past burst out with them.

For a heartbeat, the fog-drenched graveyard even fell silent.

The Old Caretaker turned and glanced at the hut door, at the corner above the frame where the hidden compartment lay. Like most veteran Guardians, he had chosen, in the year he retired, to rest the weapon that had followed him for half his life above the last door he guarded. He had never thought that he and this old partner would stand together again in front of that door.

"We guard a door… we are Bartok's Wardens…" The old man's back was still bent. In the cold, dim fog, he slowly turned, his eyes falling on the swaying shapes as he recited the oath Guardians had passed down for generations: "We swear to guard the boundary between life and death. The dead rest because of us. The living sleep in peace because of us…"

The twisted freaks in the fog grew restless. Countless swaying figures began to cross the path, rushing toward the little hut that still stood.

What answered them was the Old Caretaker's gunfire and the whistle of his blade-staff cutting the air.

"If you will not rest, I will send you to rest!"

The sounds of hacking and slashing, of roars, and of rifles and shotguns roaring together made the graveyard tremble at the Guardians' final battle.

Inside the Warden’s hut, Annie curled her small body up by the door, holding her head as she listened to the noise outside.

She began to sob softly, and finally, under the roaring gunfire, her sobs turned into loud, helpless crying.

At twelve years old, she had been tricked by Grandpa Caretaker once again.

…

At the same time, off the coast of Frostholm.

The spreading fog was not limited to the city-state itself. By noon, it had already drifted past the inshore boundary and covered the patrol range of the Sea Mist Fleet.

In such dense and eerie fog, even the curse Fleet, which itself carried an supernatural nature, had to stay on edge.

On the bridge of the Sea Mist, Tyrian stood before the wide viewports, brow tightly furrowed, staring at the wall-like fog over the sea. First Mate Aiden came up behind him and reported in a serious tone: “Up to now, our links with Cold Harbor, Ice Bay, and Pirate Island have all been severely disrupted. We get no response on any band. Our communications with the Frostholm navy and the Harbor district on Frostholm Island are also affected, but we can still barely get through. The fog has spread to at least a hundred nautical miles beyond Frostholm Island…”

“In addition, according to the boats we sent to the edge of the fog, the spread of the fog has stopped and its density is no longer increasing. But every attempt to sail out has failed—all the boats that tried to leave the fog just circled in place and, without noticing, turned back into the depths of the fog.”

“How is the Stargazing Room?”

“They still could not see the proper star chart,” First Mate Aiden said, his face grim. “It is as if a blurry lens has suddenly appeared between the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep Sea. Every star we observe has a double image, and the mental strain from stargazing has risen sharply. It is impossible to observe for long.”

“…It seems the blockade is complete. The city-state of Frostholm and the surrounding sea have already been cut off from the ‘normal world’ outside,” Tyrian said, expressionless, his single eye calm. “Do not waste effort trying to run.”

“A blockade… who put this blockade up?”

“Try using your head once in a while—do you really need to ask?” Tyrian glanced back at Aiden. “The cultists. That bunch of madmen who worship the Abyssal Lord. They are the ones stirring up trouble lately, are they not?”

“I know that.” Aiden stared, his face clearly saying, Is this not a bit much? “But can a bunch of cultists really pull off something this big?”

“A rabble of madmen may not have that kind of power, but the ‘Lord’ they worship is another matter,” Tyrian rested his hand on the rail before him and spoke in a low voice. “The Abyssal Lord… sealing space and time, disturbing the stars… so this is the power of the Elder Gods…”

Aiden swallowed hard without thinking.

“So… this time we are really going to stand against the power of an Elder God?”

“Scared?”

“A little,” Aiden nodded, but a twisted grin still squeezed onto his face. “But there is no help for it. The world is like this. When we went up against the old captain back then, did we not grit our teeth and charge anyway? At least now the old captain is on our side.”

“That is enough. Have everyone get ready,” Tyrian let out a slow breath and waved to his First Mate. “After being away from Frostholm for so many years, it seems we are about to stir up this sea again.”

Chapter 408: The Roar in the Sea Mist

The deep, solemn sound of the steam whistle echoed over the sea. Sacred steam gushed from the ship's core compartment, shaking the tall smokestacks of the Sea Mist and every intricate pipe inside them. As the whistle blared like a war horn, all the sailors moved into action.

Hoists creaked to life, sending propellant charges and heavy shells into the combat magazines beneath the gun turrets. Steam lines roared without pause, driving sacred vapor into key mechanisms and blessed sections of the ship. Sailors ran along the decks and corridors, heading for their battle stations.

When the whistle sounded a second time, the small Cathedral at the Sea Mist's stern rang its bronze bell. The bell, symbol of the Storm Goddess's divine blessing, called Gamona's grace down upon this fearsome warship that the world knew as "The curse".

On the other main battleships of the Sea Mist Fleet, similar bells and whistles sounded in turn. The bells of each shipboard Cathedral echoed through the fog, faintly resonating with one another in some strange way. Their joined peals even began to disturb the Mortal Realm itself, so that the thick mist over the sea seemed to thin and scatter just a little.

At the same time, as the Sea Mist Fleet moved, the Frostholm Navy patrolling the nearby waters also answered. Flags went up, signal lights

flashed, and the blast of whistles and the ringing of their own shipboard Cathedrals' bells echoed through the fog in response.

At that moment, the two fleets set aside fifty years of tangled grudges and hatred before the Visions that had come down on everyone. Under the strange and deadly fog that sealed the sea, the navy of the living and the fleet ruled by the Undying had become the only forces that could still rely on one another.

No one knew when the enemy would appear or in what form, but everyone knew that from now on, every unfamiliar ship that showed itself on these waters was an enemy.

Even any so-called friendly ship that refused to answer signals was also an enemy.

The enemy was the sea itself.

Every nerve on every ship was taut as they waited for some change in the fog, waited for new messages, orders, any scrap of information from Frostholm Island itself. No one knew how long that crushing wait lasted. Then Tyrian, who sat in command on the Sea Mist, suddenly felt something strange.

It was as if a gaze had fallen on him, yet it did not come from any clear direction. It felt like a look that crossed time rather than space, cast from the distant past to rest quietly upon him now.

He looked up in shock and instinctively glanced around the Sea Mist's bridge.

First Mate Aiden was talking with the boatswain. The communications officer was exchanging coordinates with the Frostholm Navy. The elderly black-robed priest had already hurried over from the small Cathedral and now sat beside the gunnery officer's station with eyes closed in prayer. With

the thick fog blocking all view of the sea, the priest’s Spiritual Insight would be the warship’s greatest reliance when fighting the enemy in the mist.

Farther away, a figure stood quietly by a porthole.

In a daze, Tyrian remembered a scene from fifty years ago. In that yellowed memory, Her Majesty the Queen had personally come aboard this warship. Back then the Sea Mist had not yet grown through those fifty years. It had been older and more weathered in a different way, and the Queen had stood in that very spot, her gaze fixed on the distant sea for a long time.

It was from that place that she had given the order for the Sea Mist Fleet to leave Frostholm three days later.

Now that figure slowly turned its head and gave another order.

“Tyrian, defend Frostholm.”

After half a century, the second order had finally arrived.

Tyrian jerked awake. His heart hammered, and his eyes burned and stung as if he had just stared straight at some knowledge close to the Truth itself. Noise roared in his mind. Before he could even think about whether what he had just seen was an illusion or something else, the urgent alarm bell suddenly rang on the bridge, cutting off all his thoughts.

As the bell clamored, he already caught sight of something on the distant sea out of the corner of his eye. Amid the swirling fog, a massive ship’s silhouette was rising out of the thick mist, as if the sea itself were bulging upward to shape a Ghost from days long past.

The Ghost’s masts stood tall, and its old-fashioned funnels jutted up like coral growths on the back of a sea beast. It slowly adjusted its heading and moved toward the flank of the Sea Mist Fleet.

It was so close they did not even need the priest’s Spiritual Insight to find it.

“Visual contact! Silhouette identified, third-party vessel!” the lookout shouted.

“Open fire,” Tyrian said as he strode back to his captain’s chair, his voice as cold and heavy as an iceberg. “Anything that appears on these waters and is not already on our identification list is an enemy.”

In an instant, the guns roared and thunder crashed.

On the Sea Mist, the three main turrets that had the best angle opened fire one after another. The heavy armor-piercing shells, already primed and waiting, shot from the barrels with a peal like thunder. In the thick fog they became blazing meteors falling from the sky, slamming toward the silhouette in the distant mist.

Almost at the same time as the Sea Mist opened fire, a series of cannon blasts rolled out from that bank of fog as well. They sounded like distant thunder. In a chain of flashing fire, lines of flame tore through the mist and plunged down toward the sea around the Sea Mist.

Tyrian sat quietly in his chair, eyes half narrowed, listening to the distant rumble and calculating the shells’ flight.

It was an old 356-millimeter main gun, four triple turrets… which old friend was it?

The Rune Duke, which had once escorted the Queen? Or the Knight, which had bravely gone down in a storm fighting the Deep Sea Spawn? Or… the Warrior?

The howling of the shells was like the wail of a banshee. Thunder falling from the sky shattered what little calm remained on the sea. Huge explosions threw up waterspouts dozens of stories high, and even the fog

hanging over the water was ripped apart by the shockwaves, torn into countless pale, swirling currents.

Not a single shell from beyond the fog landed near the Sea Mist, and the Sea Mist's first salvo was the same.

"It's the Knight. Watch its broadside quick-firing guns," Tyrian said, opening his eyes. His voice was not loud, but it carried clearly to every sailor. "At this range those quick-firing guns can already do real damage. Increase pressure in the steam core and open the distance."

"Aye! Increase steam core pressure! Open the distance!"

Deep within the Sea Mist, its "heart" let out a low roar. The whole ship began to accelerate and slowly turn. On the nearby sea, great sheets of drift ice also began to surge forth, spreading in all directions like some living thing to shape a battlefield favorable to the Sea Mist.

As the ship began to maneuver, Tyrian suddenly noticed fire flaring outside another porthole at the edge of his sight, along with a distant shadow.

First Mate Aiden shouted at once: "Second vessel sighted! No response on radio, not on the identification list!"

Before Aiden finished speaking, another low rumble came from afar.

"Third vessel! Not on the list!"

"Signal from the Sea Crow! They have already engaged multiple enemies!"

"Message from the Frostholm Navy! Fighting has broken out in the waters near the city-state!"

"First and second main batteries prioritize the Knight. Third main battery and long-range secondaries handle any other enemies that enter range," Tyrian said. His voice did not change at all as more and more enemies appeared on the sea. He simply kept his calm gaze fixed on the silhouette

within the fog that was still firing and pushing through the ice toward them. “Do not worry about how many enemies there are. Everything unfamiliar that appears on this sea is an enemy. This is only the beginning.”

First Mate Aiden also shouted: “You heard the captain! Whatever shows up out here, we hit it! Even if these old relics have come back to life, they are still no match for the Sea Mist Fleet. Keep firing!”

With the orders from the bridge, all the Sea Mist’s main and secondary guns began firing salvo after salvo. Blazing fire again and again lit up the dark, chaotic fog.

Amid the thunder of guns, more and more unrecognized ships kept appearing on the wide sea.

Just as Tyrian had said, this was only the beginning.

mirror world Frostholm was rising. The border of the Mortal Realm was blurring in the fog. Things that had once sunk beneath these seas were now entering the Mortal Realm in great numbers as replicas.

And from now on, everything that appeared on this sea would be an enemy.

“Let’s raise hell!” Aiden’s hoarse bellow rang across the bridge. The bald giant wore a grin that was almost feral. Clearly he had not enjoyed a fight this fierce in a very long time. “Let out fifty years of pent-up fire, brothers! Show those navy weaklings what the Sea Mist Fleet really—”

Suddenly the noisy First Mate’s voice cut off. It was as if an invisible hand had grabbed his throat. Aiden’s eyes flew wide as he stared fixedly in one direction, and a second later, Tyrian knew why he reacted that way.

Another ship’s silhouette suddenly appeared in the nearby fog and then shot straight across the battlefield at almost unbelievable speed. That silhouette was unlike any of the enemies that had appeared so far, unlike any famous vessel Tyrian knew.

It was a mass of solid black mist, a patch of tangible shadows, a hazy, unreal thing that only vaguely took the shape of a ship. It burst out of the fog like some eerie shadow cast backward out of a mirror, howling as it rushed straight toward them. Yet more than the strange shape of this “shadow ship”, what truly struck the Sea Mist’s crew into instant silence was the “shadow” reflected on the sea beneath it.

It was clearly another ship, one wreathed in eerie green flame, a “ghost ship” that looked even more uncanny and terrifying than a mirage to everyone in the Sea Mist Fleet.

This twin ship, using the sea as a mirror, burst out just like that and howled across the water. One hull raced above the waves trailing billowing black smoke, while the other rushed below the surface streaming pale green flame. It almost scraped along the Sea Mist’s side as it sped past and, in the blink of an eye, had already reached the far side of the battlefield.

Tyrian could have sworn to his Father that he had never in his life seen a large ship move at such outrageous speed.

Chapter 409: Twins

Amid the roar of gunfire, that strange twin ghost ship had cut straight across the fight and thundered past right under the eyes of both sides. Forget the crew of the Sea Mist—Tyrian even felt that the replica warships deep in the fog had all frozen in place for a few seconds.

Then he heard Aiden's voice beside him: "C-captain, that thing that just rushed past seemed to come out of the fog too. Do we… shoot it?"

On the bridge, every pair of eyes turned toward their captain, because the words he had just spoken still rang in all their minds:

Once the battle began, everything new that appeared in this sea would be an enemy.

"…Shoot my ass!" After a few painfully awkward seconds of silence, Tyrian finally glared and snapped, "Can you even catch up to it?! And did you not see that ship's reflection in the sea?"

Aiden shrank his neck at once, a strip of light flashing across his bare scalp. He spoke in a hesitant voice: "I saw it. That reflection… it looked wrapped in spirit flame."

As soon as the First Mate finished speaking, a low rumble came from deep within the Sea Mist's hull, and the whistle above the deck suddenly blared. This former Vanished Fleet flagship, reshaped by supernatural powers, seemed to be responding on its own, confirming the First Mate's judgment.

“Even the ship felt it,” Aiden said, looking around and then turning a complicated gaze to Tyrian. “Captain, what do you think that ship was?”

“…Perhaps it was Father’s doing,” Tyrian said in a low voice, his expression grave. “Don’t dig into it. Keep fighting. Also notify all friendly forces, including the Frostholm Navy, not to block that strange… forget it. At that speed, I doubt they could anyway…”

Before he finished, the seaman monitoring the radio suddenly received a message. The man stood up and reported loudly: “Captain! The Frostholm Navy cruiser Sea Hawk just sent word. A ghost ship of strange shape and incredible speed just shot past their bow, heading straight for Frostholm Island. They’re asking if it is ours.”

Tyrian pressed his fingers hard against his brow, then waved his hand after a moment. “We can’t mention anything about the Vanished to them. Just say it’s a friendly ship and give no further explanation. Once the battle settles a little, I’ll go ask ‘him’ myself.”

“Yes, Captain!”

The cannons kept roaring. The fire and explosions in the fog did not quiet at all because of this brief interlude. Between the towering columns of water rising in the distance, Tyrian’s thoughtful gaze pierced the mist over the battlefield as he silently looked toward the direction where that strange ship had gone.

…

“I think we almost rammed into something just now!”

Lawrence hurried from the porthole back to his desk and spoke loudly to a Pocket Mirror sitting on the tabletop. Then he anxiously glanced outside again. The sea beyond the porthole looked dim and hazy, as if countless

shadowy, unreal things were floating on the surface, making it impossible to tell what was real and what was only a phantom.

And the White Oak itself was racing through those phantoms at an astonishing speed.

Black mist rippled across the mirror's surface, and within the fog appeared a female Adventurer wearing a captain's uniform.

"We didn't ram anything," Martha said with a cheerful smile. "We only almost did."

"Almost ramming it was scary enough!" Lawrence grabbed the Pocket Mirror, walked toward the window, and spoke quickly. "I didn't notice when we had no point of reference, but—just how fast are we going?!"

"Very fast. Very, very fast, a formless phantom, crossing the waves like the wind," Martha said with a smile, looking into Lawrence's eyes through the mirror. "Do you remember what you told me many years ago? You said you would rebuild the White Oak and the Black Oak into the finest vanguard exploration ships, and then skim across the sea with me like the wind… My love, right now we're at least at a force seven or eight."

"That was a metaphor! A metaphor!" Lawrence's eyes showed a hint of terror, because as he spoke he watched another massive phantom slide past the porthole so close it nearly scraped the glass. Its bridge towered high, and the turrets along its side pointed toward some faraway target. It was locked in fierce battle with an enemy in another layer of reality, while the White Oak-Black Oak pair seemed to rush straight past the mouths of its main guns.

After a moment, Lawrence tapped his forehead and sighed. "Forget it. As long as you can keep us safe. What exactly is going on out there now?"

“We are passing through a war zone,” Martha answered in a gentle, calm tone.

“A war zone? Who is fighting?”

Martha turned her head in the mirror, as if observing the situation on her side, then looked back. “The Frostholm Navy of the Mortal Realm, and the famous Sea Mist Fleet. Their opponents are the replicas rising from mirror world into the Mortal Realm.”

Lawrence felt his heart sink and his expression grew solemn. “…So the final moment has come?”

“It seems so,” Martha said softly. “mirror world is overlapping with the Mortal Realm now. The final ‘Inversion’ has already begun.”

“Why so soon? You said this wouldn’t happen for a while yet.”

“I could only make rough guesses, Lawrence. After leaving the ranks of the replicas, my connection to this mirror world world has been fading quickly. I don’t know what has happened, but clearly someone is deliberately speeding up mirror world’s Inversion…”

For a while Lawrence did not speak. He only stared out the window at the hazy, chaotic sea and the endless drifting phantoms. After a few seconds he suddenly asked, “Are we still sailing in the mirror world waters?”

“Yes. We are still trapped in this mirror world world,” Martha nodded. “But the barrier between mirror world and the Mortal Realm is blurring. We do not have much time left.”

“If the Inversion really completes, what will happen?” Lawrence asked.

“A city-state will become a cradle for the Elder Gods to descend. What do you think will happen?” Martha replied calmly.

Lawrence pressed his fingers to his temple without thinking.

“…Damn it. How far are we from Frostholm?”

“We are almost there,” Martha said, raising a hand in the mirror to point outside. “I can already see the lights of the Harbor district from here. Countless ships are gathering in the surrounding waters: half a century of wrecks, endless replicas. But they are all ignoring the Black Oak, at least for now.”

Lawrence nodded gravely. He picked up the mirror he used to speak with Martha, opened the door, and left his captain’s cabin. As he walked toward the bridge, he asked in a low voice, “Once we reach Frostholm, what do you need me to do?”

“Find their nest. The power that created and sustains this mirror world world lies deep within Frostholm. I can sense its general location,” Martha said. The smile she always wore faded into seriousness as she looked into Lawrence’s eyes, her tone very earnest. “Once you start searching for it, the replicas surrounding the city-state should react at once. I will find a way to hold them off.”

“…Can we handle that with only the Black Oak and the White Oak? You said yourself there are countless ships gathering…”

“We are part of the Vanished Fleet, Lawrence,” Martha said, a faint smile returning to her lips. “And we are not the only ones taking part in this battle.”

Lawrence reacted at once and glanced thoughtfully out the corridor window.

Those vast, hazy ship shadows were fighting on the distant sea. As time passed, the boundary between mirror world and the Mortal Realm was growing even more blurred. Soon this entire stretch of ocean, including

both mirror world Frostholm and Mortal Realm Frostholm, would be aflame.

“I understand,” Lawrence said, nodding. He pulled his gaze back from the window and continued quickly toward the bridge. “But I have one last question. I can lead the team into Frostholm, but how are we supposed to deal with that… thing in the depths of the city-state? If it really is, as you say, an Elder God or a part of one, ordinary weapons may not work.”

The bridge was ahead.

Lawrence steadied himself and stepped forward to push the door open.

His First Mate, his Second Mate, the ship’s priest, and his crew members were all waiting for him there.

There was also that strange Anomaly 077-sailor. The mummified corpse had somehow found a crewman’s cap from the White Oak and put it on its head. It now sat quite properly in a chair, watching the other crew members at work with curious, focused attention.

Lawrence walked toward them, and the crew members all rose to salute him.

Martha’s voice came from the mirror: “You will have help.”

Lawrence returned his crew’s salutes. When he heard that, he looked at Martha in the mirror in surprise. “Help?”

“Yes, help. For many years they have been fighting in the depths of this mirror world world, trying to break through the great gate that leads to the deepest part of the city-state, but they have never succeeded. Go and find them. You won’t need to explain why you came. They will naturally become your allies… probably.”

“Probably?!”

“Because I am not sure what they really are, or whether they can even communicate with people. Lawrence, you know this. I have wandered here for many years, but I have never had much freedom.”

“All right, I understand. Help,” Lawrence sighed, and his tone could not help but hold some curiosity. “I thought we were the only ones fighting the replicas around us. I didn’t expect there to be others. Who are they?”

“They call themselves… the Queen’s Guard Corps.”

Chapter 410: Fog Panic

The clicks of switches being pressed kept sounding in the secret room. Metal springs hummed with a steady rhythm as they connected and disconnected. Invisible signals were sent up to the roof and transmitted by an antenna disguised as a weather vane, while messages from the Sea Mist Fleet were sent back into the room, transforming into the clacking of relays and neat rows of round holes on a strip of paper.

With headphones on, Nemo sat at the desk, listening to the sounds in his ears while he tapped his fingers on the tabletop in slight irritation. A young woman in a waitress uniform stood beside him, picking up the paper strip that had just been spat out by the punch-card machine and reading the pattern of holes.

After a while, Nemo pulled off his headphones and leaned back in his chair. He pinched the bridge of his nose and let out a long breath.

“Captain Tyrian has already started fighting the strange fleet that appeared in the fog. The Frostholm navy’s situation is unclear for now, but it doesn’t look good,” the young woman holding the paper strip lowered her voice and spoke nervously. “Yet there hasn’t been a whisper of news in the city…”

“The thick fog has cut off all civilian news channels. Even if the residents on the coast hear the guns, they won’t know what is happening. The city authorities have to keep order in the inner districts—panic on a large scale won’t help the navy at all,” Nemo said, still pressing his brow. “What’s it like out on the streets? And in the tavern?”

“The Constable units have put the whole city under martial law. The streets are very quiet now, but just now I thought I heard gunshots from far away. Two steam walkers passed the corner of Oak Street and hurried north,” the young woman answered. “The tavern is still fine for now. We have enough fuel for lighting, but…”

“But?”

“There are more than a dozen guests trapped here by the thick fog. The streets are already sealed, and the Sanctuary Worlds are full. They have nowhere to go. If this drags on, fear is going to build up among them.”

“…We still can’t drive them out onto the street. Right now, the tavern is their temporary Sanctuary World. And if we really throw people out, it will definitely draw the Constables and the Church,” Nemo shook his head. “I’ll go up in a while and see what’s happening.”

As soon as the Sea Mist Fleet informant finished speaking, a muffled muttering suddenly came from a corner of the room: “Charge again, charge again… They’ve broken through… Reinforcements are here too…”

Nemo frowned at once and stood, looking toward the source of the sound.

There was a bed there. An old man in ragged clothes lay on it, half-conscious, his back hunched. He clutched a heavy wrench from who knew where to his chest, and he did not seem to be resting peacefully.

“Old Ghost, Old Ghost,” Nemo walked over and patted the old man’s shoulder. “Having a nightmare?”

The old man clutching the heavy wrench opened his eyes in a daze. It took him several seconds to speak: “Who are you?”

“I am Nemo,” Nemo Wilkins said, his expression a bit complicated. “What were you dreaming about?”

“Nemo… Oh, Nemo, I remember now. You’re the new recruit in the Queen’s Guard Corps… Hello, I’m the pipeline engineer of the Second Waterway… A dream? I didn’t dream. I just nodded off, just nodded off… What time is it now? Should I be going to inspect the power conduits?”

“It’s already afternoon,” Nemo shook his head. “Forget about the power conduits. We’ve pulled out of that place for now. Nowhere is safe at the moment. We have to stay at this base and wait for orders—that’s General Tyrian’s command.”

“General Tyrian…” Old Ghost’s eyes went blank for a second, then he suddenly seemed to snap awake. He sprang up from the bed: “Yes! Engineer Wilson has received the order! Standing by at the base!”

Nemo’s expression grew a bit more complicated, but he still slowly straightened and returned the old man’s salute. Then he turned and nodded to the young woman in the shop assistant uniform: “Stay here and look after Old Ghost. I’ll go upstairs to check the situation.”

After giving his instructions, he left the secret room and took a hidden passage back to the tavern on the surface.

Inside the Golden Flute tavern, a heavy, tense mood filled the main hall. The guests trapped there by the thick fog, the shop assistants and the waiters on duty—almost everyone watched the street outside the display windows. But wherever they looked, they saw only dense fog and the hazy outlines of the street within it.

All the gas lamps in the city had already been lit early. The man-made lights barely pushed back the gloom brought by the eerie fog, but not enough to make this muddled world clear again. Those yellowish balls of light floated in the mist like rootless duckweed, looking like rows of eyes hovering above the streets.

Nemo came out from the kitchen door and walked to the counter.

“How is it?” he asked quietly, speaking to the shop assistant behind the counter.

“Everyone is nervous. All traffic and communication with the neighboring streets are cut off. No one knows what is happening anywhere else,” the shop assistant whispered. “But at least no one has cracked and run outside —no one wants to dash into that fog right now.”

Nemo nodded slightly: “If some idiot really does show up, don’t stop them. Let them go—but once they step through this door, even if they spend only a second in the fog, you must never let them back in. From now on, this place allows people out but not in. Anything that comes out of the thick fog is to be treated as something of the Malevolent Spirits by default.”

The young shop assistant swallowed nervously and nodded hard: “Yes, shopkeeper.”

Just then, a strange buzzing suddenly came from the street, cutting off the conversation between Nemo and his subordinate.

It sounded like some device starting up, mixed with the noise of heavy machinery moving along the street.

The people in the tavern grew restless. Some hurried nervously to the windows to see what was happening outside. Someone spotted some moving red lights in the fog and gasped in a low voice: “Steam walkers… more walkers have appeared!”

Nemo also walked toward the windows. When he was halfway there, the strange buzzing suddenly rose in pitch. A distorted loudspeaker voice blared from outside the glass—it was the broadcast device mounted on a steam walker calling out.

“Zzz… A notice to all citizens… The governor and the leaders of the Church are working to restore order in the city-state… Frostholm is currently being affected by unknown manifestations, and we are… A special reminder: residents, please remain at home or in a safe shelter facility. For your safety, stay as far as possible from anything around you that can produce a reflective surface, including but not limited to mirrors, water surfaces, and polished metal…

“We repeat: stay away from anything around you that might produce a mirror-like surface—anything at all.

“In addition, if you notice anyone near you behaving strangely, hide at once in a safe, enclosed space, and if conditions allow, seek help from the person in charge of your shelter or from the nearest Guardian or Constable. Do not rashly attack anyone you find suspicious. First ensure your own safety and isolation.

“If you feel that your own condition is abnormal, also please hide at once in a safe, enclosed space and avoid talking to others as much as possible…

“The above reminder comes from His Excellency Governor Winston and the expert advisors in the field of the supernatural.

“Notice to all citizens…”

The broadcast voice slowly faded away, and the steam walker’s red warning lights sank back into the thick fog.

Nemo lifted his head and saw all the tense eyes around him.

But he reacted quickly.

“Go get some cloth!” he shouted to the shop assistants and waiters. “Cover every glass counter and mirror!”

The others reacted as well. Though they were still anxious, the city's residents clearly had basic knowledge and mental preparation for saving themselves in an supernatural disaster. The shop assistants quickly fetched the dust covers they usually used after closing time, and the guests still in the tavern hurried up to help. They quickly draped cloth over everything in sight that might create a reflective surface.

Similar scenes were playing out in every corner of the Frostholm city-state.

The terror of the fog was spreading over the whole city-state.

In the drifting heavy fog, Agatha had already returned to the Cathedral.

In the lounge beside the great hall, she met Bishop Ivan, who had just finished his work.

The Bishop had climbed out of the spirit coffin he usually rested in and had pulled the robes of an Archbishop over the bandages that wrapped his whole body. In Agatha's memory, it had been many years since she last saw Bishop Ivan dressed like this.

"Even this corpse of mine has been forced to crawl up and work," Bishop Ivan in his robes sat in a chair and spread his hands to Agatha as she entered. "I haven't moved outside my coffin for so long that I feel like I've fallen apart from exhaustion."

"If you still have a body that can 'fall apart'," Agatha said casually, "how are things now?"

"'How are things'—everyone is asking that. They couldn't be worse," Bishop Ivan's hoarse, low voice came from under the bandages. "replicas are attacking the city. Monsters that had been hiding are starting to show themselves. Just now, several graveyards were attacked. Those places where the dead were stored temporarily seem to have been used by the enemy as 'passages' into the Mortal Realm. City Hall has also sent word: gunfire has

been heard on several streets in the Lower City. And out at sea, our fleet is already fighting the things that have crawled out of the water.

“The full assault has begun. But worse than the enemy’s full assault is that we still don’t know the full shape of this disaster—or this plot. Those heretics hiding in the dark… How did they do all this? Where are they hiding?”

As he spoke, Bishop Ivan slowly raised his head and looked into Agatha’s eyes.

“What did you find underground? From your eyes, I would guess you saw something.”

“I didn’t find the heretics’ lair,” Agatha said, “but I found… something even more disturbing.”

Agatha drew a slow breath, paused for a moment, then said: “It seems that our Boiling Gold mine dried up decades ago—or even longer ago.”

Chapter 411: Tracking

The room fell silent for a moment.

The silence lasted for more than ten seconds before Agatha finally heard Bishop Ivan's deep, hoarse voice come from beneath the bandages: "Ah-oh."

"…Your reaction is a bit unexpected."

"Because your information is too unexpected," Bishop Ivan seemed to finally recover. He adjusted his sitting posture, and his tone became very serious. "You're saying the Boiling Gold vein of the Frostholm city-state ran dry decades ago? That's the truth you found down there?"

"Yes. In the deepest part of the Second Waterway there is a door, probably sealed by the first City Hall. Behind the door is a mine tunnel that has long since dried up. Judging by its position, it should be in the rich deposit zone at the bottom of the mine—the area that would, in theory, be mined last…"

Agatha did not hold anything back. She recounted everything she had discovered underground, and as she spoke, Bishop Ivan's gaze visibly grew heavier.

After a while, Agatha finished describing what she had seen below, but then added with some hesitation: "…That was only one tunnel. There are countless tunnels in the mine. Even if it's the deepest part of the rich deposit zone, we still can't judge from that alone that the entire mine has dried up. So a large part of my conclusion is guesswork… I know this guess is too wild."

“…Yes, a rather wild guess,” Bishop Ivan said slowly. “After all, if the Boiling Gold mine really ran dry long ago, then what have we been hauling out of the mine over the past half century? What is the Boiling Gold catalyst that Frostholm has been shipping to other cities all these years?”

Agatha said nothing. She knew there was no way to avoid the questions Bishop Ivan raised, and no way to answer them.

The Frostholm city-state had always produced the highest-quality Boiling Gold ore and finished catalyst rods. In the past fifty years, the output of Boiling Gold from Frostholm alone was almost equal to the combined total of all the other city-states around the Frost Sea. Boiling Gold in the mines flowed out endlessly. The mining machines devoured wealth day and night, and the smelting plants sent out catalysts to the whole world. Ships that used those catalysts sailed across the Boundless Sea.

And in that whole half-century, not a single Boiling Gold order had ever gone wrong.

If the vein had truly run dry decades ago, then never mind just the Frostholm mine—what had been burning in the steam cores of all those ships on the Boundless Sea? Phantoms?

After a long time, the Gatekeeper could only sigh softly: “…If that too is a creation of corruption, then our world has truly become absurd to a frightening degree.”

“Our world has always been absurd. But perhaps… this time you really have found a key clue,” Bishop Ivan shook his head. “Let’s not worry about whether the guess itself is crazy. From a rational viewpoint, the contradiction between a vein that ran dry decades ago and a mine that is still producing steadily now is very likely tied to the anomalies currently afflicting the city-state.”

“…But according to the clues we had before, the current anomalies should have been caused by the cultists of Oblivion,” Agatha reminded him. “What do they have to do with the mine?”

“They might not be connected to the mine at all—they may simply have used and triggered this crisis,” Bishop Ivan said, thinking quickly. The experience of decades, especially his experience dealing with cultists, was helping him piece this puzzle together. “Those heretics couldn’t have been laying out a plan in the city-state for decades without being noticed. What’s more, the drying up of the vein might go back to the time of the Queen. In that era, Frostholm’s suppression of heresy was far harsher than today. No cultist could have escaped the Queen of Frostholm’s eyes…”

As he spoke, the old Bishop paused, then suddenly asked: “You said just now that Governor Winston knew nothing about the door deep in the Second Waterway?”

Agatha nodded: “That’s what he said.”

“…I don’t really believe him,” Bishop Ivan said, hesitating as he shook his head. “The situation was indeed somewhat chaotic in the time of the first City Hall, but the handover between the first few governors and their administrations shouldn’t have had such a huge gap—especially not with a secret this crucial and sensitive…”

“You mean Governor Winston is hiding something from me?” Agatha frowned. “Why would he do that?”

“I don’t know. Maybe to maintain City Hall’s authority. Maybe because this secret is tied to something bigger. It could even be that something has already taken control of him. It’s hard to say,” Bishop Ivan said. His gaze suddenly settled on Agatha. “What surprises me more is that you didn’t grow suspicious about this. You never used to overlook things like that.”

Agatha froze.

In that brief moment of shock, she recalled what she had experienced on the way back from the Second Waterway—the reflection in the pool, and the "other self" in that reflection walking in the opposite direction.

"Agatha, what's wrong?" Bishop Ivan's voice pulled her out of her distraction.

Agatha blinked and shook her head lightly.

"Are you sure you're all right?" There was obvious doubt in Bishop Ivan's tone. "You've drifted off more than once these past two days, and…"

"I'm fine. I've been fine all along," Agatha interrupted the old Bishop. For some reason, after that brief daze, her tone now sounded relaxed. She let out a soft breath and rose from her chair. "I just suddenly figured some things out—I should set out."

Bishop Ivan stood up: "…You're heading to the mine?"

"The navy is holding back the enemy. The Constables and Guardians are keeping the situation under control. They've bought us time. I still have a chance to find the source behind all this. It's time to go."

Agatha paused for a moment, as if to stress her point, then added: "Time is limited. I can't rest here for long."

"All right, then go," Bishop Ivan nodded lightly. "I hope you can uncover the truth smoothly and come back safely."

"I will uncover the truth."

…

In the thick fog, distant gunshots rang out from time to time. Now and then they were joined by warning broadcasts from Constable or Guardian units,

and the automatic sirens of certain facilities.

The city-state was now a blur in the fog, and unseen terror seeped through the mist.

“All things considered, I’d rather face hundreds or thousands of fully armed cultists, or charge back and forth a few more times in a city that’s burning to the ground.”

Vanna dismissed the greatsword of solid ice in her hand and frowned at the ground in front of her as she spoke.

Within their limited field of view, the ground was crisscrossed with terrifying cracks. Filthy black sludge slowly flowed and writhed in those fissures, then quickly began to harden. Some of the sludge even barely kept the outline of a human form, yet its key limbs were twisted in ways that made one’s skin crawl.

“Too disgusting,” Vanna muttered.

“Honestly now, would you really like to fight another battle in a burning city?”

Morris’s voice came from the side. The old scholar held the Gatekeeper’s cane in one hand, glanced at the shattered “battlefield” before them, and spoke casually to Vanna.

“…All right, no, I don’t,” Vanna shrugged. “Whether it’s a replica city-state shrouded in thick fog or a burning city under the Black Sun, neither is any better.”

As she spoke, the thick fog flowed, and a tall figure suddenly loomed out of the mist behind Vanna. Its head was swollen and misshapen, a giant single eye trembling violently in the fog. The next second, the monster lunged at Vanna.

But Vanna did not even turn around. She simply stomped hard on the ground. An invisible shockwave spread out in an instant, and the deformed twisted entity only managed one step before its lower body shattered. It crashed to the ground and quickly turned to sludge.

Under her conscious control, Morris, who was only a few steps away, was not affected at all by the shockwave. The old scholar merely adjusted his blessed monocle and calmly looked around at the fog-filled streets.

The next second, he suddenly looked toward a certain spot, a gleam of silver rising in his eyes: “McKafini Conjecture and Proof.”

The next second, a series of dull explosions, like watermelons being stomped to pieces, came from the fog. Several vague figures appeared in the mist, their heads bursting like fireworks.

“The good news is that these low-quality replicas imitate thought to some extent, and whoever controls them needs a mind as well,” Morris said, withdrawing his gaze as the silver light faded from his eyes. “At first I worried they were all empty shells of chaos. In that case, the power of knowledge wouldn’t have worked very well on them.”

Vanna watched the monsters with blown-off heads slowly turn to sludge in the distance, her expression a bit strange. She glanced back at Morris: “Back when you taught me, you never said the ‘power of knowledge’ was this useful.”

“At the time I had already decided you weren’t suited for this path,” Morris said offhandedly.

Vanna: “…”

The Inquisitor felt, for a moment, that she was being mocked. But when she recalled her exam scores back then, she decided to keep a humble attitude.

“Any more nearby?”

She stayed alert as she asked quietly.

“None for now,” Morris shook his head.

He kept sensing the surroundings at all times. When those monsters emerged from the fog, their chaotic thoughts appeared in his perception first. The mist could block human sight, but in his eyes the radiance of thought shone like lanterns in the night.

Very few people could actively control their own thoughts. So in the field of “Detect Sentient Minds”, no one could compare to the Saint of the God of Wisdom.

“Good that there are none for now, though new ones will crawl out soon enough,” Vanna exhaled and flexed her arms and legs a little. “Have you noticed… that in this direction, there are a lot of replica freaks, and they attack much more aggressively than elsewhere?”

“You noticed it too?” Morris raised his eyebrows. “Then it seems my judgment was right.”

“You mean…”

“Not all of the ‘replicas’ emerging from the fog are acting blindly. Some of them are being controlled by someone behind them.”

Chapter 412: Academic Exchange

Ever since they left the mountaintop, Vanna and Morris had been fighting the endless replicas in this fog. They no longer remembered how many monsters made of elements they had destroyed on the way, but one thing was clear: no matter how many they killed, the monsters were always quickly replaced by more coming out of the mist.

Simply killing these replicas was useless.

Morris cast his gaze into the thick fog. Faint silver light flowed now and then in his eyes. He tracked the flashes of thought that sometimes appeared in the mist, trying to use them to find where the controller behind those monsters was.

After a while, he suddenly raised his head and looked in a certain direction: “This way.”

Vanna immediately reached out and grabbed at the air. A new greatsword condensed from the omnipresent fog. She strode ahead of Morris.

They moved through the fog, along empty streets where no one was left. They relied on the dim streetlamps around them to barely tell where the nearby buildings were. From time to time, distant sounds reached their ears —sometimes the Guard Corps of the city-state fighting monsters, sometimes eerie howls and roars, and sometimes even cries for help that sounded as if they were right beside them.

But wherever the cries for help came from, there was only surging black sludge.

The fog flowed, and the outlines of buildings inside it seemed to flow with it. The hazy shapes looked as if they had come to life. Towers in the mist turned into flesh-and-blood giants. Huge tentacles and eye stalks spread from the rooftops. Even the streetlamps on both sides began to sway, their dark posts bending like soft plants, while the lights turned into clusters of murky yellow eyes.

Just then, a low, gentle prayer sounded from ahead. It broke Morris's thoughts and made the scene before his eyes snap back to normal.

Vanna was murmuring a benediction. Layers of radiance, like ripples on water, spread outward from her and stirred the dense fog.

After finishing a short prayer, Vanna spoke without looking back: "Be careful. Something in the fog can disturb people's minds. We have stayed in it for too long."

Morris answered casually: "It actually doesn't affect me much. Seeing and hearing things that aren't there is normal for me. I am already used to it."

"…Next time I write to Heidi, I should talk with her about your ideas of health."

Morris's mouth twitched. He was about to say something when a stream of moving fog suddenly drifted in from the side. His vision blurred for a moment, and then Vanna vanished from in front of him.

The Old Scholar stopped at once, watching the surroundings with full alertness as he called out: "Vanna?"

The fog quietly flowed. No one answered his call.

Morris's nerves grew tighter bit by bit as he quickly scanned the area.

He did not know when it had happened, but all around him there was only endless pale fog. The buildings he could barely make out before were gone.

Even the dim streetlamps had disappeared from his sight. In the depths of that pale chaos, he suddenly saw something.

They were vast Shadows, like huge towers. On a closer look they subtly swayed and wriggled. They seemed to be tentacles of some enormous sea monster, stretching from the sky down toward the ground, licking at everything on the earth. Morris was unconsciously drawn to the blurred outline of that huge tentacle. He stared at it and felt as if he could draw Truth and secrets from its huge, terrifying Shadow—

The next second, Morris frowned and shook his head.

There was no Truth in that thing. It was only some kind of mind-twisting illusion.

“Hm?”

Morris heard a voice in the fog. It sounded like someone was surprised. He instantly looked toward the source of the sound. The huge illusion in the distance vanished, and a tall, thin figure walked out of the fog.

The newcomer spoke in surprise: “You actually weren’t affected—that is truly surprising.”

The tall, thin figure grew solid. It was a middle-aged man in a dark blue coat, holding a Black Leather Tome in his hand. Behind the man, a black chain stretched from the bones of his neck up into the air. At the end of the chain floated a jellyfish-shaped creature, swelling and shrinking like smoke.

Morris said nothing. He used his gaze on the cultist who had a symbiotic pact with the Smokewisp Jellyfish, watching every one of the man’s movements.

The middle-aged man smiled instead, his tone oddly calm, and said: “Don’t be so tense, old man. I actually don’t mind chatting with you. The final day of descent has already come anyway, and I have plenty of time now. I’m

really curious. After seeing the form of the Lord, why weren't you affected? You can see those visions, which means your Spirit Sight is strong enough. But you… didn't go mad?"

Morris spoke calmly while silently reciting the name of the God of Wisdom Rahm in his heart: "Sorry. My mind has always been healthy. I am not going to fall into chaos because of a few mind-twisting illusions. Where did you take my companion?"

"You should stop worrying about others first, old man. Right now you—"

The cultist had only said half a sentence when Morris's eyes suddenly sharpened. He raised his hand and pointed at the man: "Lomonosov Inequalities!"

Vast knowledge compressed into a single phrase. A flood of information crashed into the target's thinking. The cultist's body shook at once, and he lowered his head as if in great pain.

But just as Morris was about to unleash a second Mental Blast, a strong sense of alarm suddenly sounded in his heart. He snapped his mouth shut and forced his thoughts to a halt. Almost at the same time, he saw the cultist suddenly raise his head, a hint of mockery in his eyes.

The Mental Blast rebounded. Morris felt a wave of dizziness at once—but thanks to his quick reaction, the dizziness was not too serious.

The cultist spread his hands and looked mockingly at the swaying Old Scholar: "What a pity. I don't seem to be very afraid of that…"

"Boom!"

Before the cultist finished speaking, the Smokewisp Jellyfish floating behind him began to contract violently. The next second, as the jellyfish suddenly swelled, a huge black fireball appeared in front of the cultist. The

fireball screamed through the air and, a heartbeat later, smashed hard into the spot where Morris had been standing!

Black smoke and dust spread, making even the thick fog around them shudder violently. The Annihilator looked at the still-rolling smoke and shook his head with regret: “So many ‘shells’ were wiped out by your mental shocks. Did you think I would show up without any preparation? Sadly, knowledge is not the same as wisdom.”

“Clang—crack!”

A sudden clatter of something falling to the ground cut off the cultist’s muttering. His eyes widened. He used a spell to call up a violent gust of wind that blew away the black smoke. A shattered Prismatic Lens appeared before his eyes.

On the broken surface of the Prismatic Lens, there was still a faint afterimage of Morris.

“A Prismatic Lens? *Optical Deceptions*?!”

The cultist suddenly understood and looked toward a spot nearby. Almost at the same moment, Morris’s figure appeared in that empty stretch of ground.

The figure raised his right hand toward him and spoke slowly and clearly, word by word: “McKafini Conjecture and Proof.”

This time, the cultist who had a symbiotic pact with the Smokewisp Jellyfish did not even sway. He dropped all pretense and grabbed the chain floating behind his neck. As he drew on the power of Abyssal Demons, he stared hard at the Old Scholar not far away and said: “Sorry, but I actually graduated from the mathematics department of Morka City-State Central University…”

“Click.”

The crisp sound of a gun's action reached his ears. Another figure of Morris appeared directly behind the cultist. A revolver pressed against the back of the cultist's head.

"Bang!"

With the shot, the head-split corpse fell to the ground, and the Abyssal Demons bound to it by a symbiotic pact let out a howl and quickly dissipated.

"You could have mentioned earlier that you graduated from university."

The Old Scholar blew on the gun barrel, put the gun away, and shook his head. In front of him, the other "Morris" faded like morning dew. At the spot where the illusion vanished, a small crystal Prismatic Lens fell to the ground and shattered.

Morris looked at the broken Prismatic Lens with some heartache. Then he lowered his head and poked the cultist's corpse with his Gatekeeper's cane in disdain.

"You made me waste two prisms—and your university degree."

As he spoke, the fog around them suddenly started to flow again. The scene inside the mist changed quickly. The building outlines and lights that had vanished appeared once more in Morris's sight. Right after that, he saw Vanna running quickly toward him from the side.

Before she even reached him, Vanna called out nervously: "Are you all right? You suddenly disappeared just now…"

Morris waved his hand: "I thought you were the one who disappeared. Looks like it was only some kind of temporary illusion… wait."

Something suddenly came to his mind, and at the same moment, Vanna stopped a few meters away.

The two of them spoke at the same time: “First we need to confirm if it’s really you.”

They looked at each other and, again in unison, said: “the Vanished!”

“Looks like it’s really you,” Morris said with a nod after making sure nothing was wrong with either of them. “There is nothing wrong with being careful.”

Vanna was the first to notice the cultist’s corpse on the ground. Her eyes changed slightly: “You dealt with this?”

Morris nodded: “I ran into someone with a high level of education. We had a round of academic exchange. Luckily, I had a better way to solve the problem.”

Vanna: “…?”

Chapter 413: The Next Record

Although Vanna had known Morris for many years, in her eyes he had always been just a gentle, cultured Scholar. Back in the city-state of Pland, this old mister spent most of his energy in the classroom. The rest of his time was either spent in the library or being invited by various schools to give lectures.

Vanna had not had many chances to see what this elder could really do in the supernatural field.

But ever since she went aboard the Vanished, she finally started to see another side of Morris and realized what those harmless-looking Scholars who followed the God of Wisdom Rahm relied on to carry out their work—

It was one of the most dangerous jobs in this world: the pursuit of knowledge.

But when she thought about it carefully, it made sense. Scholars should have their own unique and powerful strength. After all, there were many beings in this world that chased after knowledge—from Abyssal Demons to Spirit Realm phantoms and more. Yet in the end, most knowledge still fell into the hands of mortals. Why was that? Because mortal Scholars had strong academic power…

Vanna rubbed her forehead and forced herself to stop her wild thoughts. She muttered: “So you were this strong… If I had known, I would have paid more attention in class back then. Maybe I could have…”

Morris shook his head with a straight face: “No. Your grades were far too low. Training your body suits you better.”

Vanna felt a little embarrassed: “I still graduated from the city-state university in the end…”

Morris glanced at her: “One third of your credits came from athletics, and one third came from Church training.”

Vanna fell silent. After a few seconds of quiet, she looked toward the thick fog around them and forced the topic to change: “The cultist you killed should be the controller behind those replica freaks, right?”

Morris shook his head: “At most, he was only one of the controllers. Did you hear the sounds coming from the other districts? The whole city-state is full of those monsters now. Who knows how many cultists have already used the thick fog to enter the Mortal Realm… We will not be able to wipe them all out by ourselves.”

Vanna nodded with a grave expression. She was about to say something else when something caught the corner of her eye. She let out a soft: “Huh?”

She walked over to the dead Annihilator, crouched down to examine the body, grabbed the man’s collar, and tore it open.

The flesh under the clothes was melting and writhing, showing the look of being soaked in the corruption of black sludge. As the body’s true life faded, the movement of that sludge slowed visibly and then began to dry up.

“This is also a replica?!” Vanna’s eyes widened in shock. She could hardly believe what she had found. “These cultists… even turned their own people into replicas?!”

“No, it’s not that simple,” Morris said with a frown. He was also carefully inspecting the cultist’s body while recalling details of the battle. After a

moment, he slowly shook his head. “I sensed his thought waves. They were not the same as a replica’s. replicas have clear breaks in their thinking that are different from humans. Even if they can act like normal people, the instability of elements itself keeps them from maintaining a stable mind. This cultist did not have that problem.”

As he spoke, he pointed to the flesh on the cultist’s chest that was covered by black sludge.

“And more importantly, look at this part. He is not completely made of elements. elements and normal flesh exist at the same time. This looks more like a symbiotic pact, or… self-corruption.”

Vanna stared at that place for a long time, and her brows slowly furrowed. “These heretics actively used elements to corrupt themselves? They even replaced part of their own flesh with elements… That is disgusting. Even for Annihilators, this level of perversion is impressive.”

Morris’s tone stayed calm: “I don’t think it’s much different from those Annihilators who turn themselves into Abyssal Demons. These madmen hate the mortal flesh of this world. They never mind using the craziest methods to remake themselves.”

As he spoke, his attention shifted to something else.

He looked at the Black Leather Tome the cultist had been holding in his hand.

After a brief hesitation, the Old Scholar reached out and tugged the book free from the cultist’s tightly clenched fingers.

“Careful,” Vanna warned at once when she saw this. “That book may contain filthy, blasphemous content. The power of the Sun has already weakened. If you touch it rashly…”

Morris shook his head lightly: “Scholars always open new and mysterious books. For us, every act of reading is a challenge and an adventure. Don’t worry. The Rahm sect has special training and techniques for reading in situations like this. You just need to stand guard for me. And if anything is drawn here by this book, help me deal with it.”

Vanna hesitated for a moment, then nodded with a serious face: “…All right.”

Morris gave a soft “mm” and finished a quick prayer in his heart. Then he took a small vial of herbal powder from his coat. He poured half of it on the ground and lit it, and sprinkled the other half over the book before him. After that, he checked the state of the colorful rune bead bracelet on his wrist. Only then did he sit cross-legged on the ground with due solemnity and place the book on his lap.

The book’s cover was pitch black. There were no words or symbols on the surface, only faint, fine net-like patterns pressed into the hard shell. There was no way to tell where it came from.

Morris opened the cover and looked at the contents inside.

Vanna turned her gaze away, trying her best not to be affected by the book.

Some messy lines and symbols came into Morris’s view.

At first, he could not understand what he was seeing at all. The messy symbols and lines did not match any language or ancient script he knew. But when he tried to turn to the next page, the marks on the paper suddenly began to move. The ink strokes turned into living, crawling things that rushed through the prison of the paper. The jumping characters pricked at the Old Scholar’s vision. In just a few seconds, he felt that he had already begun to understand what the pages were recording.

The symbols and lines twisted rapidly. Everything on the pages trembled before his eyes, and the “knowledge” was projected straight into his mind!

Morris’s heart stirred. The defenses and reflex measures he had set up in his sea of consciousness activated at once. In the next instant, his main awareness pulled back and his reason solidified. He seemed to turn into a bystander, standing behind his “self” in the Mortal Realm from a lofty, unreal angle, calmly and clearly reading the contents that were appearing in his own mind.

“…The meetings of the forsaken Elder Kings were held again and again, and the first plan was set…”

“Those who were abandoned—their flesh would melt in the light…”

After reading only two lines, the phantom “self-projection” of Morris frowned.

This was what had been written on the slip of paper that the young informant named Crow brought back when the captain first led a team to explore the Second Waterway. It was that vague, origin-unknown passage that seemed to be some kind of ancient record—the Sacred Script!

Morris’s eyes changed slightly. He at once controlled his body to turn the pages, letting his eyes read those twisted, blasphemous lines and form the matching memories in his mind, then read that content from his bystander’s point of view.

He saw more Sacred Script. And after the section Crow had copied, there were indeed more broken sentences:

“…After the forsaken clan departed, the creation of all things still went on as planned. The forsaken Elder Kings began to design the first and final Blueprint…”

“Yet that first Blueprint was soon cast aside, for the aftershocks of the Great Annihilation kept raging through the mortal world… the Elder Kings gathered dust into stone, and stone into stars, but the stars shattered and broke apart and could not endure…”

“Thus the pale king of the giants, ‘Salmir’, fell in the first Long Night of the Genesis Protocol…”

“…Then the Elder Kings began to design a second Blueprint. They chose one among themselves to be the Creator. The first chosen one was the King of Dreams, also called the King of Knowledge and Memory, for this mighty one had indeed shown sacred miracles of creation…”

“But the second Blueprint also failed. The King of Dreams was torn apart in the second Long Night of the Genesis Protocol, and part of Him drifted along the border of the Mortal Realm…”

“The third Blueprint was entrusted to another king to carry out. His name was the Crawling King, also called the Lord of the Swarm. He was the common master of countless tiny, unseen things. He held the divine authority of creation and also the divine authority of the opposite of creation… And there was a Truth that called Him the ‘Big Brother of Wisdom’.”

“…Then the Crawling King began His work. In the third Long Night, He gave the Blueprint to the swarm and sought a helper from the clans that still remained. To avoid repeating the fate of the King of Dreams and the pale king of the giants, He divided that Blueprint. He made it so that the mortal world would no longer have nations. The nations became one thousand and two hundred cities, and He let that clan rule the first ten cities and gave them the name ‘Critt’.”

“Thus the third Long Night passed in peace. This was good.

“Yet the forsaken Elder Kings were displeased with the Crawling King for changing the Blueprint, and they blocked His way back to the holy throne. But the clan of the Ten Cities was grateful to the Crawling King. They did not dare praise this king before the Elder Kings, so they gave Him another revered name. They called Him holy, and named Him—

“the Abyssal Lord.”

Chapter 414: Connection

Boom!

A thunder-like roar exploded in the depths of his mind. Morris almost lost control of himself in that instant. Even with his main consciousness placed under Consciousness Isolation and the shelter of Mind Solidification, his mind was still swept up by the spreading shock. The storm of information that followed crashed over him like towering waves, and he almost fell into it.

In a flash, the “psychological vantage point” that stood behind and to the side of his own body began to spin. The words inside his head vanished from his view. All he felt was endless mist coiling and rising. The lines he had just read turned into a swarm of bees in a runaway state, ramming around in his memory and gnawing at fragments of his personality. For a moment he even forgot his own name. Only one title remained in his mind, the one he had seen in the last second.

Abyssal Lord.

But in the next moment, that spinning, world-turning feeling was suddenly stopped by something. Morris felt his consciousness dragged back by a force of terrifying strength, pulled hard toward the world of the Mortal Realm. During that pull, he saw arrays of flickering lights appear in the thick mist. In the middle of those many lights, one great red light source burned.

For a second, it felt as if God of Wisdom Rahm had cast a single glance at him. Then those arrayed lights quickly faded and turned into a huge wave that crashed toward him.

Right after that, the huge wave broke apart before his eyes and became a cloud of pale dust. The fine, white ash fell around him like the ashes of the Saint.

Then the pale dust began to burn in midair, turning into a falling Rain of Fire. Countless bright, red streams of flame formed inside it, surging toward him as if they meant to burn him to nothing.

But just before the red flames fell onto his body, Morris saw all of the fire suddenly shine with a layer of ghostly green. The raging, exploding fire became gentle in an instant and fell down around him bit by bit. One tongue of flame brushed his shoulder. He at once felt someone slap him hard. The next second, he snapped his eyes open and realized he was back inside his own body.

The effects of Consciousness Isolation and Mind Solidification had been cut off by force. He had once again returned from the state at the madness threshold to this world.

The moment his awareness came back, Morris fought the urge to “take one more look” and slammed the Black Leather Tome shut with all his strength.

He moved fast, but even so, the book still flipped several pages wildly before it closed. Out of the corner of his eye, some trembling words etched themselves deep into his mind with a powerful impression as they flashed past. It was one sentence, filled with a dying kind of stubborn will:

“We will at last return to that pure and holy origin.”

The Black Leather Tome finally closed. Morris panted hard, his mind still filled with the words he had seen at the last second.

Vanna noticed something was wrong at once. She hurried over in just two steps: “How are you?”

“…Just a Scholar’s daily life, dealing with deadly knowledge and then surviving.” Morris caught his breath, then held out his hand to Vanna. “It’s fine. I’m still me – help me up.”

As soon as he stood, he asked: “How long has passed?”

“A few seconds,” Vanna answered with a nod. “I just saw you open the book and glance at it a few times, then you suddenly snapped it shut. At the same time, your Spiritual Insight was shaking non-stop, and strange Shadows started to appear in the fog around you.”

“A few seconds…” Morris pulled at the corner of his mouth. In his mind, he recalled the strange scenes he had seen when he was dragged back from the edge of the runaway state.

In the next instant, a deep and solemn voice rose in his mind: “Morris, what happened on your side?”

Morris froze for a moment, then quickly straightened his expression and replied in his heart: “I was reading a copy of The Blasphemous Tome we seized from an Annihilator just now and got hit by corruption by accident. Captain, was it you who pulled me back at the end?”

“Yes,” Duncan replied. “I suddenly felt your mind under attack, so I used the mark I left on you to check on the situation. You said you seized The Blasphemous Tome? What exactly happened? Are you still with Vanna? Where are you now?”

“Vanna and I are together. We’re still operating in the Upper City. We found that some Annihilators used the fog as cover to enter the Mortal Realm and control a number of replicas to attack the city-state. We just found and eliminated one of the controllers,” Morris answered at once. Then he took a

moment to gather his thoughts before going on. “The situation is strange. After that cultist died, his body fused with elements, like some very extreme kind of ‘modification’. He was carrying a Nameless Black Grimoire. The content of the book…”

Morris suddenly stopped. His tone became extra careful, and he kept a tight hold on his thoughts. “The things written in it are disturbing. They are the original text of those Sacred Script accounts that Crow copied earlier. I only had time to read a small part before I suffered corruption. I’m sorry, I can only report this much right now. I can’t let myself recall the details inside yet.”

Duncan was silent for two seconds, then spoke again: “That is enough. Safety comes first. Do not keep recalling what you saw. Bring the book with you and report to me face to face later.”

Morris let out a small breath of relief: “Yes, Captain.”

Just then, Vanna “spoke” from beside him: “Captain, how are things on your side?”

“Alice and I are at the Second Waterway. It is quiet here.”

Deep underground, near the center of the city, at a junction of the Second Waterway, Duncan raised his head and looked down the empty hall ahead.

A thin layer of mist drifted above the corridor, close against the dark surface of the dome. The mist seemed to appear in this space out of nowhere, and it grew thicker as time passed. But compared with the surface of the city-state, which was already covered in heavy fog, the mist here was not serious.

“I am waiting for the Fire Seed to get into position.”

Using the link of the mark, he said this to Vanna in his heart.

“Fire Seed?” Vanna sounded confused.

“The nests of those Annihilators are not in the Mortal Realm. mirror world Frostholm is their real base,” Duncan said slowly. “Whether it is the city-state’s Sea Fog Fleet or the Frostholm navy, and even the Guard Corps and the Guardians of the Church, all the ‘invasions’ they destroyed in the Mortal Realm only slowed the rise of mirror world. Only by acting from the mirror world side can we truly solve this problem.

“Agatha has already gone ahead with the Fire Seed. She will find the cultists’ nest, and then I will help her burn that place down.”

Vanna was quiet for a few seconds before she answered, clearly a bit hesitant: “Then… is there anything we can do?”

“Just keep hunting in the fog. Destroy every replica you see. Find all the controllers behind them. Kill as many as you can,” Duncan said. “Slowing the invasion still matters. You are buying time for Agatha and easing the pressure she will face.”

Vanna answered at once: “Yes, I understand!”

A few seconds later, her voice sounded again: “Also… there may still be one replica ‘Gatekeeper’ moving inside the city-state, and the Church does not seem to be reacting at all. Do you think…”

Her voice held some doubt.

But Duncan already knew about that replica, more clearly than Vanna did.

After all, he had already made contact with the real Agatha.

“Do not worry about that ‘Agatha’,” he replied after a short pause. “And you do not need to try to take her down. But if you meet her and the situation calls for it, you may offer help.”

Vanna went silent for a few seconds on her side. When she spoke again, she sounded shocked: “Offer help?! Help that replica?”

“Do not forget, not all replicas are under the control of Annihilators. The best of them have their own will,” Duncan said calmly. “A Gatekeeper will not easily become a puppet of Heretics. Of course, you will still have to judge the exact situation for yourselves if you meet her.”

“Yes, I understand, Captain.”

This time, Vanna’s answer carried a special kind of solemn weight.

It was as if her sense of duty as an Inquisitor had, in that moment, formed a subtle bond with that “Gatekeeper”.

His link with his followers came to an end.

Duncan let out a soft breath, then raised his hand. A small flame bloomed at his fingertip.

He stared at the flame for a moment, then asked softly: “Agatha, do you really think ‘she’ will act the way you believe she will?”

A cold, hoarse voice came from within the fire: “She will.”

“Why are you so sure?”

“Because I believe in myself.”

“But she is only your replica,” Duncan said calmly. “There will be small differences between you. Those differences might make her choose a different path from yours.”

“But you did not order your followers to wipe out that ‘risk’,” Agatha said. “You also believe in my judgment.”

Duncan stayed quiet for a few seconds before he let out a soft sigh.

“There was once a human named Brown Scott who proved his humanity to me. That humanity still held true in a replica. So this time, I do not mind believing one more time.”

“If… I mean, if my judgment is wrong too, what then? Your trust will be wasted…”

“It is alright. It is a small matter.”

A small matter…

In the cold, damp sewer corridor, Agatha lowered her head and looked at the little flame still burning quietly in her palm.

The faint warmth that came from that flame seemed to be the only warmth she could still feel in this world. Outside the circle of firelight, the whole world felt as cold as a grave.

The Captain’s voice came again: “Agatha, how is it going on your side?”

“I am still moving forward. I am almost there. I can feel it. It is very close.”

“I meant you. Your voice does not sound the same as before.”

Agatha stopped walking.

She lowered her head. All she saw was her own wounded body, covered in scars, and the injuries that no longer bled.

“It is alright,” she said softly, her voice cold as a tomb. “It is a small matter.”

Chapter 415: Going Down the Shaft

Agatha shielded the small flame in her hand and stepped forward again, heading deeper into the Second Waterway.

In truth, she had already lost her sense of time. Even her sense of everything around her had grown blurry. She could no longer remember how long she had been walking in this cold, damp place. She could not remember how many Monsters she had killed, or how many new wounds she had gained in the process. For a while, she even forgot her own name and why she had come into this sewer.

But whenever the green flame leapt in her palm, she would always find her reason again and hold tight to that single, final mission.

Carry the Fire Seed. Deliver the Fire Seed into the nest of the Heretics.

A cold wind blew from the dark corridor ahead. It seemed to carry layers and layers of whispers and howls. Agatha's body swayed a little. She felt the malice inside the wind, so she carefully hid the flame inside the torn inner layer of her black coat.

She had to hide it. She could not let the Heretics sense it.

She raised her head and looked into the depths of the dark. She saw countless shifting Shadows rolling in the wind. The gas lamps on the corridor walls had dimmed at some point, leaving only tiny glimmers like fireflies. Filthy black sludge began to seep out from the ceiling and pipe

grates around her, bit by bit. It squirmed, gathered, and took shape, making sickening, whispering noises.

Agatha lifted her Gatekeeper's cane, which was as scarred as she was. For some reason, she suddenly felt filled with strength again. That annoying sense of exhaustion had quietly faded away.

She slammed the Gatekeeper's cane hard against the ground, staring at the foul, corrupted things surging in the dark. The tip of the cane hit the floor with a boom like a great bell.

"Dong…"

The Shaft Lift creaked. The car swayed as it sank deeper into the mine. A Guardian warrior standing watch by the edge of the car suddenly looked up. He spoke to the Comrade next to him with some doubt: "Did you hear something just now?"

"It sounded like a dong," the other Guardian said, nervous and unsure. Then he turned his head almost by reflex to look at the Gatekeeper standing in the middle of the car. "Like… like…"

Like the sound when the Gatekeeper struck the Death Knell with the Gatekeeper's cane before a purification of Heretics began. He wanted to say that, but he kept it to himself.

Because the Gatekeeper was here. She was resting with her eyes closed.

Maybe she heard her subordinates talking, because Agatha opened her eyes. She glanced around, then walked in silence to the rail at the edge of the car and looked down.

"Gatekeeper," the Guardian who had spoken earlier came over and said, a bit hesitant: "It seemed like some sound came from below just now. Could there be someone else also acting in the mine?"

“We are the only ones here,” Agatha said without turning her head. “Do not worry about that sound.”

Her subordinate stepped back for the moment, but Agatha kept looking down into the endless, hazy dark below.

This was the Boiling Gold mine, the largest vertical shaft leading to the lower digging areas. Even this deep inside the mountain, the fog was still everywhere.

Under normal conditions, fog could never reach a place like this. But this strange mist was clearly the result of supernatural power. It seeped in everywhere as if it had a will of its own. In areas deep underground where the lights were weak, the mist filled every space as if it had appeared out of nowhere.

The mine’s Shaft Lift groaned as it kept descending through the haze. From time to time, they could see faint blobs of light moving upward. Those were gas lamps and electric lights set inside the shaft. They looked so weak that, through the fog, they were no more than tiny glimmers like fireflies.

But no matter what, the equipment in the mine was clearly still working. The ventilation system, power pipes, lighting, and lifting gear all still ran normally.

Using machines at a time like this called for extra care. Agatha had sent priests to check the condition of the lift machinery on purpose before she chose to use this Shaft Lift. The safer choice would have been to go down by the stairs and ramps in the emergency tunnel, but that would have cost too much time and strength.

“I just hope this thing does not break on the way back up,” a young Guardian warrior muttered under his breath. “That cargo car and track that crashed down the slope during the runaway state was pretty unforgettable.”

“Can you not say things like that right now?” an older Guardian frowned at once. “We are all on the Shaft Lift. If you are that nervous, you can jump off instead. Free falling will not break down on you.”

“No, no, I was just saying. This thing looks strong and steady. It will be fine…”

A Nun with ear-length short hair heard the two warriors talking and came over to join in: “But I heard there is a female Inquisitor in the far-off city-state of Pland. She can jump straight off a cliff onto the rocks below to cut down a Spawn. If she jumped from here, she would be fine…”

The two Guardians fell silent for two seconds, then spoke in unison: “…Is that even a human?!”

“I only heard about it…”

The warriors kept chatting. It would not affect what they had to do later, but it helped ease the tension of this slow descent into the dark. Guardians were people too. They needed to relax their nerves.

Agatha stood with her back to them. She did not join the talk, but she did not stop her subordinates either. She only listened quietly. At some point, a faint, almost hidden smile had appeared on her face.

Unlike what many imagined, the usually serious and steady Gatekeeper was in fact always gentle and tolerant with her subordinates.

Just then, the steel cables pulled tight and the sound of the brakes came from around them, cutting off the Guardians’ conversation.

The Shaft Lift car began to slow down and soon stopped in a wide, cold space.

“This is the transit point on the first level,” Agatha said as she looked around. She saw the nearest supports and lights, and the scattered mine

equipment on the open ground nearby. The workers had clearly left in a rush and could not take everything with them. Traces of their hurried retreat were everywhere. “Where is the Mine Transit Map?”

“Here,” a priest stepped forward at once and handed the Mine Transit Map they had taken from the mining office to the Gatekeeper. “We are at Shaft No. 2 right now.”

Agatha took the map and walked off the Shaft Lift while comparing the information to her surroundings. At the same time, she recalled the details she had learned from the mine managers before going down: “The underground rail line to the digging zone has stopped running. To reach the digging zone we can only walk. We follow the red line markers. About one hundred and fifty meters from here there is a ramp that leads down to the mining face.”

She raised her head and checked the area again.

“First, check the surroundings and set up a safe point. Then we move deeper.”

The subordinates got to work at once. The Guardians went to check the safety of each passage. The priests and Nuns began simple purification of the ground around the Shaft Lift and set up a temporary altar and sacred relic.

Agatha wandered slowly around the area.

She stopped in front of a transport crate that had been left behind and knocked over.

The crate was made of iron. The inside was lined with tin layers. The lid had not been latched. When it fell, it had broken open, revealing its contents. Inside were chunks of ore broken into small pieces.

The ore had a dull metallic sheen. On the dark outer skin, faint gold lines ran like veins.

“They were probably samples meant to go up with the next shift for testing,” a middle-aged Guardian walked over and said, judging with some experience.

To scout the mine, about half of the subordinates Agatha brought this time were Guardians who had worked long-term in the Boiling Gold mining area. They were not professional Miners, but they still knew quite a bit about the place.

“Boiling Gold raw ore…”

Agatha’s face grew serious. She nudged a few pieces of ore on the ground with her Gatekeeper’s cane, then bent down and picked one up to examine.

A moment later, she handed the ore to the middle-aged Guardian: “Check it.”

“This is good quality ore,” the Guardian said after taking it. “Looks like it only needs simple crushing and first screening before it can go into The Crucible. I cannot say much about the yield… that needs a specialist.”

Agatha frowned: “That is all? No problem at all?”

“I see no problem. It is just ore,” the Guardian answered plainly. Then he looked a bit puzzled. “Do you suspect something?”

Agatha silently picked up another piece of Boiling Gold ore and studied it for a long time before she spoke softly: “What I am about to say is only a guess, but it is also classified. Only those taking part in this operation may hear it, and only after coming down the shaft.”

The Guardian facing her was startled for a second. But in the next moment, the warrior’s face was already solemn and steady.

Surprised, but not panicked. Caught off guard, but not lost.

Every priest who had the right to follow the Gatekeeper on a mission – whether Guardian, Nun, or priest – had already been chosen carefully inside the Church. They had all sworn oaths and signed contracts under Bartok's gaze.

Each of them knew how special their duty was. They knew how strange and difficult the cases that needed the Gatekeeper herself could be. On these deep dives into the dark, anything could become classified. Something ordinary one second could become a taboo that had to be shut out of the civilized world the next. Even the people who took part in the operation might at any time become part of the "secret".

After all, some things left a crack of corruption in the Mortal Realm the moment they were simply "known". Even leaving only an "impression" in the minds of those involved could plant Shadows for a future runaway state.

Agatha looked up and saw that the temporary altar and sacred relic were already in place. The safe point was set.

"Everyone, gather. I have something to announce."

Chapter 416: The Governor’s Whereabouts

Frostholm’s deepest mine tunnels had already run dry decades ago. The “lifeblood” that this city-state lived on was very likely only the result of some twisted power. At the bottom of the Boiling Gold mine, a door left behind by the first City Hall lay buried deep. The current City Hall and the Governor were very likely also part of this secret, and helped maintain it.

Even the well-trained, disciplined Guardians, who often dealt with all kinds of dangerous and uncanny things, could not help falling into shocked silence when they heard this.

After the shock, they also understood why this operation had been classified, and why the Gatekeeper had waited until everyone was already down in the shaft before revealing the exact situation.

News like this, even without considering the threat brought by the supernatural Visions behind it, would be enough to set off a storm in the city-state on the truth of the “exhausted vein” alone.

“We still cannot be sure whether all the tunnels ran dry decades ago, and we are even less sure what has been shipped out of this mine after the vein was exhausted. The only thing we can confirm is this: if all of this is really the product of some ‘corruption’, and if the Anomaly phenomena in the city-state are also tied to this corruption, then we are now standing at the origin and deepest point of that corruption.”

Agatha’s gaze swept over the subordinates around her. Her voice was as calm and steady as always.

“I believe everyone already knows what is happening on the surface. I also know you have had doubts. You wondered why, at such a critical moment, we sent one of our finest squads down here just to investigate a mine. I worry about the comrades fighting those monsters in the fog as much as you do. I worry about the battles in the surrounding seas.

“But we are also standing on a battlefield right now. If we can find out what is really going on in this mine, we will be helping our comrades elsewhere in the best possible way. We will be tracing the crisis back to its root, instead of getting trapped in endless attrition against those monsters in the thick fog.

“That is all. Does anyone have any questions?”

She looked around. What she saw on her subordinates’ faces was the same calm and firm resolve as always. She gave a small nod.

“All right, we move out. Our target is the lowest extraction level. Watch the darkness along the way, and keep checking the ventilation and lighting systems. When you came down, each of you received a Mine Rescue Respirator. Put your masks on now and open the external circulation valve. You all remember how to use them, right? If something happens, turn the valve clockwise to switch to internal circulation, pull out the self-rescue plug, and fall back toward the main drift at once. Keeping yourselves alive is the top priority.”

The Guardians and the priests and nuns moved at once. They put the respirator masks over their mouths and noses, checked the hoses and circulation valves, then clipped the special underground consecrated lanterns to the hooks on their chests so they would not slow their movements.

Agatha did not put on a mask. As the God of Death's Gatekeeper, her body was already very different from that of an ordinary person, especially when it came to "breathing". Normal toxic gases and a lack of air did not affect her actions.

Just as the subordinates were getting ready to set out, a light hissing sound suddenly reached Agatha's ears.

At first, she thought it was only the circulation valves on her people's masks as they breathed. But soon she realized the hissing came from farther away, outside the group, in the shadows beyond the reach of their lamps.

"Attention!" Agatha reacted at once and called out a warning. A second later, several other Guardian warriors also picked up the sound of a leaking valve in the darkness, and several beams of light swung toward that spot at the same time.

In the hazy mix of light and fog, Agatha saw a figure appear in that dark corner. It was someone wearing a thick black coat and a gas mask, and he seemed to be carrying a gun.

The figure lay collapsed in a pile of junk, breathing with great effort. The hissing sound was coming from his gas mask.

Why did someone suddenly appear here? The Guardians had already checked this whole junction. There was no way they could have missed such an obvious person.

A question flashed through Agatha's mind, but she did not hesitate. In a few quick steps she reached the figure, who already looked like he was dying. The Guardians followed right behind her.

"…He is a city-state soldier," one Guardian said at once, recognizing the gear on the fallen man. "From the Governor's own Guard Corps."

Agatha quickly looked the soldier over. Over his thick black coat he wore a metal breastplate. The power conduits that linked the breastplate to his arm guards were broken. His military respirator mask covered almost all of his face. She could only tell from his build that he was a male soldier. His fatal wound was near his chest. It looked as if his internal organs had been badly damaged.

One of his arms was already gone. His remaining hand still clutched his rifle.

The sudden light around him seemed to have stirred something. When Agatha came close, the soldier in the respirator mask suddenly moved a little, as if he was trying to lift his head.

The Guardians around them started in shock and grabbed their weapons on reflex. Agatha only waved a hand, stepped forward, and bent down a little.

“Who are you?” she asked.

“Governor… Guard Corps… Martin… Brad… sergeant…”

“Sergeant Brad, why are you here?”

“Governor… Winston…” The man who called himself Sergeant Brad from the Guard Corps spoke in a hoarse voice. The sound under his mask grew weaker and weaker. He said the Governor’s name and struggled to lift his arm, as if trying to point somewhere. “Mr Winston… went into a secret chamber… we need… backup…”

He did not finish. His arm suddenly went limp. From under the respirator mask came one last hiss that faded very fast.

He died. In the very next second, as his life left him, Agatha saw foul black sludge slowly seeping from his wound and from under his mask. His body collapsed as if it were melting, making a sticky, squirming sound that chilled the blood.

“replica!”

The Guardians reacted at once. They backed away in a hurry, while the priest with them stepped forward. He threw a handful of prepared powder over the collapsing corpse and then hurled a pale fireball at it.

With a bang, pale flame leapt up. The replica’s corpse was swallowed in an instant. After a fast, fierce burn, all that was left was a heap of dried, no-longer-moving black sludge and the heat that still hung in the air.

Agatha watched calmly. When the figure had first appeared, she had already guessed that it might be another replica that had crawled out of the thick fog. Now she turned in thought, looking toward the place that “Sergeant Brad” had tried to point to before he died.

“In that direction…” she murmured.

“Lady Gatekeeper, that was only a replica trying to lure us,” the priest beside her said, unable to hold back a warning when he heard her. “It could be an enemy trap.”

“But it seemed not to know it was a replica,” Agatha said with a small shake of her head. “Do you remember the intel we had before? These replicas seem to come in three kinds. One kind is dull and mindless, attacking any living person. One kind seems to be under control and causes damage in the city in an organized way. And the last kind seems to keep the original’s memories and feelings, and does not even notice it is a fake.”

The priest froze for a moment and spoke in a hesitant tone: “You mean…”

For a second, Agatha’s eyes looked a little complicated, but no one noticed that brief pause. After a moment of quiet thought, she spoke in her usual calm voice: “This replica was copied not long ago. He may still have his memories from a few hours ago, or even more recent. On the other hand, since we came down into the mine, all the messages from City Hall have

been relayed by the Confidential Secretary. Governor Winston's whereabouts seem to be unknown."

The priest reacted quickly. He understood what Agatha meant.

"The replica is fake, but its memories are real," he said at once. "Not long ago, Governor Winston may really have come here with a squad of soldiers. One of them, a sergeant named Martin Brad, may have died in the tunnels. The thick fog then copied the newly dead sergeant and his memories."

"Perhaps that is the truth."

Agatha nodded slightly, then turned toward the tunnel that their hazy lamps lit.

No one knew what waited deeper in the extraction level. But Governor Winston clearly held truths that others did not. Now, at the key moment when the whole city was caught in Visions, he had led a squad of soldiers down into the depths of this mine. Without a doubt, the biggest clues were most likely in that direction.

"Thank you for showing the way."

Agatha turned back and gave a solemn nod toward the dried sludge that no longer looked human at all. Then she swung her hand toward her subordinates and said: "Stay with me. We are going to find the Governor's whereabouts."

…

At the same time, on the endless sea under a chaotic, dim sky, the twin ghost ships swept over the waves like the wind, passing through countless ship shadows, half-real and half-illusory.

Lawrence stood at the bow of the White Oak, looking down at the rolling sea beneath him.

Between the rising and falling waves, he could already see the distant city-state’s reflection.

Chapter 417: Running Through the Fog

In the Pocket Mirror he carried, Martha's figure appeared out of a cloud of black mist. Her voice reached Lawrence's ears: "Do you see the lights in the distance?"

"I see them," Lawrence said with a nod. He looked up at the strange scene ahead. A huge ink-black phantom floated on the sea, faintly shaped like the outline of the city-state, but with no details at all. Under the surface of the water, however, he saw the bright lights of The Harbor's docks and the buildings around the edge of the city. The White Oak, with no one steering it, was slowly moving closer to this zone where light and shadow were turned upside down. Countless hazy ship phantoms floated on the distant sea, as if locked in a battle. In this chaotic view of light and dark, real and unreal, he even felt as if he himself was becoming unreal. "It is an unbelievable sight… So this is what the world looks like when you watch it from the mirror world side…"

"Light and shadow are inverted in your sight, but in mine it looks normal. Soon all of this will flip again," Martha said with a small smile. "Go get ready. I will be docking soon. The spot is an abandoned pier at the south corner of the east harbor. I will bring the ship as close as I can to a sewer maintenance hatch. Bring your mirror. I will guide you all the way to the Second Waterway."

“And then… the other replicas will react, right?” Lawrence still could not help feeling worried. “If you really cannot hold them off, take the White Oak and the Black Oak and pull back first. At our speed, those replicas will never catch you.”

Martha rolled her eyes and said: “Of course. I am not stupid. My job is just to bring you here and buy you some time. I never planned to wipe out the whole mirror world Frostholm fleet with only two twin ghost ships. You cannot kill them all off.”

Lawrence nodded and turned to look behind him.

Anomaly 077 was squatting on the deck, playing with a length of rope he had found from who knew where. Now and then he looked up at the White Oak’s funnel and flagpole, and he seemed quite troubled.

“Do people in this age no longer hang sailors who make mistakes from the mast?” the mummified corpse muttered in puzzlement.

“Still thinking about your noose?” Lawrence raised his eyebrows at once, his tone unfriendly. “Put down the rope. Go to the First Mate and draw a saber and gun with ammo. We are going ashore.”

“In the past, as soon as someone put it around my neck, I would fall asleep. Why does it not work anymore…” Anomaly 077 was still muttering in confusion. Then he suddenly reacted. “Huh? Ashore? You are taking me with you this time?”

“A strange Anomaly to deal with a strange city-state. That suits me fine,” Lawrence said, face serious. “We are going through the Second Waterway into the depths of Frostholm. Do not waste time. Go get your weapons.”

The sailor froze for a second, then caught up and jumped to his feet. “Yes, Captain!”

The White Oak drew closer to that dark zone where real and unreal were inverted, closer to the lights reflected on the sea. Behind Lawrence, a tough, elite landing squad had already formed up.

First Mate Gus was not among them. Lawrence had ordered him to stay on the ship.

The old captain's face was grave as he laid out his orders: "There will be a hard fight after this. Every replica warship near The Harbor will react and attack the White Oak and the Black Oak. You will stay on board and command the battle. Hold them as long as you can. If you cannot, retreat with Martha."

"I understand," Gus said with a nod. But he could not help looking worriedly at the "sailor" behind Lawrence, who was still fiddling with his newly issued weapons. "But… is he really reliable?"

Lawrence glanced back. Anomaly 077, the "sailor", happened to lift his head at the same time. The mummified corpse had a saber at his waist, but he had tossed the rifle and ammo pouch onto a barrel nearby. He was muttering to himself: "The saber is enough. I do not know how to use this thing."

"As you like. If you think a single saber is enough to handle the Second Waterway of the mirror world city-state," Lawrence said casually. "For someone who cannot use a gun, having one only makes things worse."

The sailor thought for a moment, then still did not touch the rifle. Instead, he walked to the weapons crate at the side and took out another saber, hanging it on his belt as well.

Lawrence said nothing. He only lowered his head and looked at his own hand.

He slowly tightened his fingers into a fist, then opened them. He adjusted his breathing and awkwardly pictured, in his mind, a warship with sails of spirit form, burning with ghost flame. He recalled the feeling of that fire burning his body, and his flesh transforming in the flames.

After a long while, he saw a faint green glow appear in the lines of his palm. Tiny flames slowly flowed along the creases.

The deck under his feet gave a slight tremor as the White Oak began to slow. The hazy darkness beyond the rail was now very close. From the Pocket Mirror at his chest came Martha's voice.

"Attention. We are about to dock. After that I will use Inversion again and cancel the Twin Projection. Jump to the pier on the left side and go straight. I will guide you."

"I am ready," Lawrence said softly. He took a slow breath and walked to the rail.

"I am ready too!" Anomaly 077 followed close behind the captain. His hoarse, dark voice held a strange hint of excitement and expectation. "Ashore! Battle! The pirate is here!"

"We are not pirates," Lawrence said, giving the mummified corpse a look. "We are honorable seafarers."

"Docking now," Martha's voice came from the mirror almost at the same time. "Three, two, one… Inversion!"

In an instant, light and shadow shifted. Real and unreal swapped places.

Everything around Lawrence seemed to flicker hard. Then the reflection in the sea rose, and the darkness in front of him reversed, as if he had passed through an invisible mirror in a single heartbeat. Frostholm's docks and piers appeared in front of him. The damp, icy chill that had always clung to him here, as if he were soaked in seawater, vanished at once.

A second later, he saw a patch of black suddenly rise on the sea beside the White Oak. Out of that shadow, the Black Oak's silhouette rushed into view.

After the Inversion of light and shadow, the Black Oak also broke free from the state of being the White Oak's reflection. The two ships now appeared side by side on the sea as twin warships, ready to fight together.

In a heartbeat, pillars of light sprang up along the docks. Sirens wailed in the distant streets. The wind howled in The Harbor with a wild, chaotic sound. From far away came the hurried boom of warship guns, like thunder in a storm.

Their response was this fast?!

Lawrence was startled, but his reaction did not slow. He kicked the rope ladder over the side and leapt out first: "Move!"

The landing squad of a dozen hardened sailors rushed onto the pier, following the route Martha gave them toward a distant intersection. Lawrence ran in the lead.

The cold wind howled past his ears. In the distance, the sirens and gunfire sounded broken and distorted. Under the dim, chaotic sky, Lawrence gripped his revolver in one hand and his sword in the other, sprinting through this twisted ghost city of the mirror world. Martha's voice kept coming.

"At the crossroads ahead, turn left and skirt the guard post… Go straight, then take the alley on the right. The entrance is at the end…"

Behind him were the hurried, messy steps of the sailors. In their hands were weapons they trusted. At his ear was the voice of the woman who matched him perfectly.

Lawrence ran faster and faster. For a moment, he felt as if the age and fatigue piled up over decades were falling away from his body. His heart beat like that of a young man. His blood rushed through his veins as it had in his prime. Those wild, high-spirited years returned to his mind.

They were back. All of them were back.

He strode forward, swinging his arms. Faint green fire appeared like a phantom behind him. At his side and behind him, similar emerald flames began to appear on one sailor after another. Their flesh-and-blood bodies took on a ghostly, unreal shimmer in the fire.

Anomaly 077's wailing voice rose beside him: "Captain! I am scared!"

"If you are scared, stay close to the squad!" Lawrence grinned, his voice oddly joyful. "This city cannot stop us!"

Anomaly 077 ran beside him, still wailing: "It is you I am scared of!"

"Then get used to it. I am not retiring anymore, and you can forget it too!"

Lawrence shouted with cheerful force. He did not care at all that his loud voice might expose the squad, or that their wild charge down the streets might draw the city's guards.

From the start, this was never going to be a "stealth" mission. The moment these uninvited guests stepped into the city of the mirror world, this living city had already reacted.

Fog slowly spread along the streets. In the strange, dim mist, shadowy shapes began to appear.

"The street is fogging up!" he shouted. "Martha, is this normal?"

"The fog marks the threshold. In fog, it is hardest to tell mirrors from reality. Keep moving. Do not worry about the fog that is seeping in from the Mortal Realm. The entrance is just ahead."

“Got it!”

Lawrence answered at the top of his voice and led the sailors into the mist. Inside it, one warped, swaying shape after another rose to its feet. Their bodies were twisted. They had the wrong number of eyes. They snarled and whispered in the fog, staggering toward the squad.

Lawrence raised his gun, but before he or the sailors could fire, a burst of dense gunshots came from the far side of the mist.

A spider-like Steam Walker suddenly appeared in the fog. Fully armed city-state Guard Corps soldiers had built a barricade around the walker. The rifles in the soldiers’ hands and the gun turret on top of the Steam Walker spat fire, tearing the monsters in the mist to pieces in an instant.

Lawrence ran past the edge of the battle zone, staring in shock at the Guard Corps that had appeared out of nowhere. A second later, the soldiers and the Steam Walker vanished back into the thick fog. All that remained where they had stood was a pile of broken rubble.

“We are here. The sewer entrance. At the end of the passage below there is a shaft lift that goes straight to the Second Waterway!”

Chapter 418: Nearing Midnight

Gunfire roared. The steam engine drove the heavy mechanical spider as it turned its body. The Six-Barrel Machine Gun spun and spat angry tongues of fire in all directions, sweeping like a reaper through the monsters that kept rising out of the fog. From time to time, bullets also came flying from the thick mist, smashing into the walker's armor and the sandbags that made up the barricade.

Among the monsters there were also "soldiers": some were fully armed soldiers, and there were even walking mechanical spiders with black sludge flowing over them.

As the battle went on, these dangerous enemies only grew in number.

"These sons of bitches are copying us!"

A soldier wearing a breathing mask hid behind the barricade. He squeezed the trigger like mad while shouting in rage. The metal armor on his body was covered in scars. The power tubes at the joints were damaged, hissing steam from broken valves. On the steam backpack on his back, the insignia of Frostholm's elite garrison was clearly visible.

"They're copying more than just us," the squad commander shouted. His voice sounded hoarse and dull behind the breathing mask. The fog in the street was getting worse, and to avoid any possible poison in it, all garrison troops entering the combat zone now wore these fearsome masks. "Anything living that appears in the fog is the enemy, it's all the enemy!"

“I just saw a group of people run past the crossroads up ahead!” another soldier suddenly yelled. “They looked like armed commoners—or sailors from a ship!”

“I saw them too. It was blurry, but they looked like they were burning, and the fire was green!”

The squad commander lifted his head when he heard this. But the next second, a strange whistling suddenly came from the other side of the thick fog, sharp and shrieking, wrapped in death.

A Grenade Shell tore through the fog, slipped through a gap between the barricades, and fell right at the feet of the Steam Walker. There was no time to react. The Grenade Shell exploded, and shrapnel burst out like rain.

The thin metal breastplates could not stop such a deadly blast at such close range. The squad commander and his soldiers were blown away together.

He did not know how much time passed before he slowly regained a bit of clarity. In the corner of his eye, he saw the Steam Walker sway and topple over. Its armor was torn open, every power tube spewed white mist, and the last remaining gun turret scattered one last burst of bullets as it fell.

Countless vague, shifting shapes came out of the fog and surged toward the next crossing.

The squad commander slowly tried to move his body. He found that his hand was clenched tight around a Hand Grenade with its pin already pulled. He could no longer remember when he had picked it up—maybe when he was thrown by the blast, or maybe during the time he was unconscious and his body just reacted on its own.

He felt as if he used up all his strength to throw the Hand Grenade into the fog.

But all he really did was let go.

The gray metal cylinder slipped from his hand, clattered as it rolled across the street, and its fuse spat thin smoke. It rolled to the side of the road and dropped into a dry drainage channel. It passed through the darkness, fell into a crack, slid along a slanted vent shaft, and dropped into Frostholm's time-worn underground world, into the forgotten dark beneath the city, where it exploded.

"Boom!"

A muffled blast came from somewhere far overhead. The ceiling of the tunnel trembled a little, and a bit of dust and grit rained down.

The "sailor" shrank his neck at once. His shriveled face showed a hint of nervousness: "This place really isn't going to collapse, right?!"

"It hasn't collapsed for decades," Lawrence said as he walked forward. The gas lamps set in the corridor walls on both sides gave off a weak glow that lit the way ahead. "And you're a mummified corpse. How can you be so timid? You're an Anomaly. You're the one who's supposed to scare other people."

"I think… digging such a huge space under a city is already scary enough," Anomaly 077 said with a tense voice. "What were you people thinking…"

Lawrence shrugged. "How would I know? I wasn't the one who dug it."

Then he ignored the mummified corpse and lowered his head to speak to the Pocket Mirror on his chest: "Martha, how is it on your side?"

"Very lively," Martha's voice came from the mirror. In the background, there were faint sounds of distant explosions and cannon fire. "After you entered the second waterway, the whole mirror world world went 'crazy'—every ship in and around The Harbor is firing at me."

"Are you all right?"

“I’m not that easy to sink. But the bad part is that the enemy isn’t easy to sink either. They keep getting reinforced from their reflections.”

Lawrence fell silent for a moment and looked into the deep, dark corridor ahead.

“How far is it from here to the deepest point?” he asked.

“Very far. But you can take a ‘shortcut’.”

Lawrence frowned. “Shortcut?”

“Did you notice the pools of water on the floor? Find a signpost, then find the puddle closest to that sign. Look at the scene in the reflection.”

Puzzled, Lawrence followed Martha’s instructions. He walked to a puddle that matched what she said and looked down at the reflection.

In the reflection he saw a crossroads. On the wall beside the crossing, a metal plaque hung. He could faintly read the words “Upper City Main Sewage Conduit” on it.

He opened his eyes wide and looked up at the wall beside him.

On the wall next to him, the worn plaque clearly said “The Harbor District Sewage.”

Martha’s voice came from the mirror: “Do you see? The world inside the mirror world is not continuous.”

“…Unbelievable… it’s like a dream…” Lawrence murmured. He looked down again at the puddle at his feet. Even as one of the most experienced captains on the Boundless Sea, he had to admit that everything in this city of mirror world was far beyond his imagination. But soon he calmed himself. “So how do we use these ‘shortcuts’?”

“You already have,” Martha said with a laugh. “Once you stand in front of this ‘mirror’ long enough, you’re already there.”

Lawrence stared for a moment, then hurriedly looked up.

In front of him was a crossroads. Dim, yellow gas lamps were mounted on the corridor walls at the intersection. On the nearest plaque, faded letters could still be read:

Upper City Main Sewage Conduit.

Anomaly 077 stared in shock at the suddenly changed surroundings. His gaze darted between the plaques on the wall and the reflections in the puddles. After a long moment, he suddenly shouted: “Is this reasonable?!”

All the sailors around them turned their eyes to the mummified corpse at the same time.

Lawrence paid no attention to the “sailor’s” reaction. He just looked thoughtfully at the dark corridor ahead, and after a long while he frowned and spoke to Martha: “We’re already in the second waterway, but where are the ‘helpers’ you mentioned before? Where are the Queenguard Corps who are fighting in the second waterway?”

The sound of distant cannon fire came from the mirror. Martha’s voice took a few seconds to reach Lawrence’s ears: “Take the left fork. Follow the red markers. Walk until there’s no road left, then stop and wait… They’ll appear. When the time comes, they’ll appear.”

Lawrence frowned. “The time?”

“…The Queenguard Corps attack at midnight, at zero o’clock—every night at zero o’clock. Before that time, they can’t be seen.”

…

In the secret room of the underground contact point beneath the “Golden Flute” tavern, the “Old Ghost” lying on the bed suddenly opened his eyes.

“What time is it…”

The old man’s eyes were still a bit blank. He muttered like someone talking in his sleep. But in the dim room, the only answer was the occasional beep from some listening device, and faint, far-off gunfire coming from who knew where.

The next second, the Old Ghost’s eyes widened.

Faint, far-off gunfire?

Gunfire!

The old man woke up at once. The gunshots reached his ears, thin and hazy, as if they passed not only through thick walls and floors, but also through several decades of time. He scrambled up from the bed and grabbed the thing leaning against the bedside.

It was a Heavy Wrench that he kept by his side even when he slept.

It was his tool, and also his weapon.

“It’s started… it’s started… I can’t sleep here… it’s time to assemble…”

The Old Ghost muttered to himself. His hands shook as he put on his shoes, then he threw on the coat that hung on the nearby chair. After that he lifted his head and looked at the room where he had just been sleeping.

This was the secret room used to communicate with the Sea Mist Fleet. Nemo had arranged for him to rest here and keep an eye on the equipment.

But the next second, the Old Ghost seemed to forget everything about this room. His eyes went cloudy again, and he looked in confusion toward the door not far away.

“Oh! The door is here!”

The Old Ghost suddenly understood and looked pleased. He rushed over and pulled open the iron door that led into the underground passage.

On the other side of the door was a narrow, cold corridor. The lights in the corridor flickered on and off, and a hissing sound came from the gas pipes due to low pressure.

“The gas line isn’t working right… not enough pressure… no, no, this isn’t the time to worry about that…” The Old Ghost stared at the lights in the corridor while he muttered quickly. He stepped forward, but then seemed to remember something and turned back to look at the secret room where he had rested.

The room was empty.

Everyone else was probably gathered upstairs in the tavern.

“Crow, I’m heading out. You stay home and behave yourself!”

The Old Ghost shouted into the empty room. Then he turned around, picked up his Heavy Wrench that never left him, and slowly walked into the deep, dark passage.

He walked toward the second waterway.

The time for the Queenguard Corps to counterattack had come.

—

Chapter 419: No Way Through?

The fog had already begun to seep into the second waterway. The hazy, dim mist floated near the ceiling of the sewer corridor like thin gauze. It felt as if the heavy roof above had vanished, and the second waterway was being slowly swallowed by the “sky.”

A short old man wrapped in a worn coat walked quickly through the strange, silent sewer corridor. Decades had worn down his body. For many years he had not been able to move this fast. Yet somehow, today, in this moment, he felt light again. It was as if youth had returned to this old shell. The ache in his joints and the weakness in his muscles were gone.

He walked faster and faster. The Heavy Wrench in his hand no longer felt as heavy as when he started. He rushed through corridors and forks from his memories, running toward a place he could no longer clearly remember, but that felt deeply familiar.

He had to catch up with the main force, because the time to assemble was almost here.

Suddenly, a pile of collapsed rubble blocked his way.

“No road… no road?” The old man stopped. He stared in confusion at the fallen stones in front of him and whispered to himself. His muddled memories scrambled in his mind, trying to explain the collapse. He seemed to recall something—

Oh, it was explosives. The Guard Corps had blown up charges in the corridor after they withdrew through the shaft to block the rebels who broke

into the sewers…

But that was not right. Not all of it. This collapsed spot was not just to stop the rebels. Many years ago, when that young soldier lit the fuse… the corridor came down and blocked something else…

The Old Ghost stood blankly before the blocked passage. Then he bent over and tapped the stones with his Heavy Wrench, mumbling under his breath.

This road should be open. It had to be open, or he would never reach the assembly point. But it had collapsed. What should he do? A wrench could not fix a cave-in…

A patch of hazy fog suddenly appeared in his sight. The Old Ghost stopped tapping the stones and slowly lifted his head. He instinctively took half a step back. He saw wisps of mist leaking from the gaps in the rubble and spreading out, filling the whole corridor and covering his view.

He heard distant whispers and roars in the fog. Then it seemed like a hoarse voice shouted: “Is this reasonable?!”

But no one appeared in the mist. As the fog drifted, the Old Ghost only saw that the pile of rubble blocking the passage had vanished.

The corridor that had been sealed off was open again. The gas lamp on the wall opposite glowed dimly. In the murky depths of the corridor, he could faintly see black sludge that looked as if it had dried up decades ago, lying still in an equally dried drainage channel.

“The road is open… good, the road is open…”

The Old Ghost’s mind blurred for a moment. He seemed to want to think about why the collapsed rocks had suddenly vanished, but the question soon drowned in his tangled memories. Without any hesitation, he stepped forward into the corridor wrapped in gloom.

…

Agatha suddenly lifted her head. The guardians, priests, and nuns following at her side all stopped at once. Everyone tensed up, ready for anything that might emerge from the fog.

“Did you hear footsteps?” After two or three seconds, Agatha finally broke the silence. “Footsteps other than ours.”

“Yes,” a nun answered with a small nod. “Just for a moment. Very faint, but very close, as if…”

“As if they overlapped with ours,” Agatha said, her face serious. At the same time, her gaze slowly swept over the nearby mine tunnel.

They were already in the depths of the Boiling Gold mine. Following the direction that “Sergeant Brad” had pointed out, Agatha and the team she led had reached this tunnel through the only passage on this side. Even this deep underground, the fog was still everywhere.

The lighting system still worked. Dim yellow light shone on the supports in the tunnel and on the tracks underfoot. Yet in the shifting shadows, there seemed to be something wrong.

Agatha saw two identical support pillars on the opposite wall. From the grain of the wood to the stain marks, every detail on the pillars was like a mirror world.

In another direction, she saw several overhead beams crisscrossed in a heap. Where they crossed, they seemed to melt into one another.

One of the priests raised a consecrated lantern and stepped up to one of the strange supports. After watching it closely for a moment, he spoke in a low voice: “Gatekeeper…”

“I see it,” Agatha cut him off. Her tone was still calm. “It’s obvious that the space where the replicas exist is overlapping with our Mortal Realm.”

“The space where the replicas exist?” a guardian repeated without thinking.

Agatha fell silent for a moment, and that annoying haze seemed to touch her again. She raised a hand to rub her forehead. “Yes. All the replicas should come from the time and space of one Anomaly. The evidence we have now shows that this Anomaly’s time and space is slowly drawing close to our Mortal Realm. Maybe… maybe we can call it a ‘mirror world’…”

She spoke with a trace of doubt. It felt as if certain pieces of knowledge just rose naturally in her mind. She said these things without thinking, then suddenly felt something odd in her body—

Cold. Boundless cold. It was as if she stood in a bitter, icy corridor, and the blood in her veins had lost all warmth.

The next second, the strange feeling vanished. The illusion of standing in some lonely, freezing passage faded away. She blinked and saw her loyal subordinates still gathered around her. The glow of the consecrated lanterns and gas lamps quickly chased away the chill that lingered in her mind.

“…Is it because there’s not enough time… or because it’s too close…” Agatha muttered under her breath.

The nearby subordinates did not hear her whisper.

One guardian warrior was holding up a consecrated lantern and checking the surroundings. Suddenly, he seemed to notice something: “Gatekeeper, there’s someone lying here!”

Agatha snapped back to herself. Her expression hardened, and she strode to the spot the warrior had found.

A warrior in the elite Guard Corps gear of the city-state lay in the tunnel. He looked like he had been dead for a long time.

He wore a black combat coat with a metal breastplate over it, and power bracers driven by a steam engine on his arms. A steam backpack was strapped to his back, and a thick breathing mask covered his face.

Agatha bent down and wiped the blood from the nameplate on the warrior's chest with her fingers. She stared at the name for a few seconds.

"It's Sergeant Brad," she said softly.

"The blood is red. The body didn't break apart or melt," a priest said beside her. "This is the 'original'."

Agatha did not answer right away.

The situation matched her judgment. The real Sergeant Brad had fallen here in the tunnel, while his replica had appeared to the church troops going down into the mine under the influence of the fog. The replica was false, but the information was true.

"There's another body here!"

Soon, another guardian warrior at the front of the team raised his consecrated lantern high and called out.

More bodies appeared in the tunnels ahead.

Agatha quickly led the group forward. Deeper in the mine, they found more and more of the dead—warriors from the city-state's elite Guard Corps, the trusted warriors of Governor Winston.

They had died in many ways. Some bodies were torn by blades. Some had crushed injuries from heavy blows. Some had gunshot wounds.

Near these bodies, Agatha and her subordinates also found dried black sludge. If that sludge were pieced back into human form, their numbers would likely be far greater than those of the fallen Guard Corps soldiers.

“…A hard battle that lasted a long time. This unit met an enemy far larger than itself in the tunnels. Yet they still fought their way forward for hundreds of meters… Most of the warriors ran out of bullets. In the end, they fought with bayonets and steam gauntlets.”

Agatha studied the nearest bodies, reading the marks left on them and the traces in the tunnel as she spoke. At the same time, a heavy unease grew in her heart.

Many warriors had fallen. Governor Winston’s group was clearly in a bad situation. This battle might have broken out several hours ago—after so much time, was the governor still alive?

As if to answer her worry, a guardian warrior clearing the way ahead suddenly stopped.

“Gatekeeper, there’s no road ahead!”

“No road ahead?” Agatha was shocked and strode forward at once.

It was just as the guardian said.

The team had reached the end of the tunnel, and in front of them was a smooth, solid wall. The path ended here.

But this clearly was not normal.

Agatha quickly turned to look back the way they had come. She saw the fallen Guard Corps soldiers lying still in the dark. Among those bodies, she did not see Governor Winston.

“Maybe the governor realized this way was blocked and took his men in another direction…” the priest guessed aloud.

“There was only one path,” Agatha shook her head at once. “And judging by the signs left here, I don’t think Governor Winston had any chance to lead the remaining guards to another route.”

The priest frowned. “But this way is blocked…”

Agatha did not answer him. Instead, she turned again and slowly walked up to the smooth wall.

After a brief hesitation, she reached out and tried to touch it.

Her fingers sank straight into the wall.

Chapter 420: Return to the Crawling Dark

Agatha pulled her hand back at once and stared at her fingertips in shock and confusion.

But the nearest accompanying Nun had already seen this strange scene. The Nun's eyes widened in surprise as she said: "Gatekeeper, just now your hand…"

Agatha frowned and for a moment did not know what was going on. Just then, a Guardian warrior stepped forward. He carefully lifted his combat Gatekeeper's cane and tapped the solid stone wall that looked no different from the rock around it.

The Gatekeeper's cane struck the wall with a sharp sound, but nothing changed on the stone surface.

The Guardian turned his head and gave Agatha a slight nod. Then he gathered his courage, stepped up, and pressed his palm directly against the wall.

Nothing happened. The wall was still just a wall.

"It is only a wall," the Guardian said with a frown. "But just now…"

Agatha said nothing. She stepped forward in silence and once again reached her fingers toward the wall.

In the next second, she watched as her fingers sank into it again!

There was no resistance at all. She even felt as if she had only touched a layer of the Veil made of phantoms.

“It seems only you can pass through it,” the accompanying priest said. He stared at the scene in shock, then turned his head in disbelief and said: “But… why is it like this? Why would there be a wall like this deep in the Boiling Gold mine? No one has ever reported it before…”

Agatha ignored the priest’s exclamation. She still said nothing and stared hard at the fingers she had thrust into the stone wall. From an angle only she noticed, she finally saw a tiny change where her fingertips touched the wall.

Her fingers and the stone at that spot seemed to melt at the same time. They melted only a little, yet they blended together like heated butter. Their color and texture looked like black sludge.

This was how she had “passed through” that seemingly solid stone wall.

She did not know how long she stayed there before she finally broke the silence in a low voice: “I do not know why this is happening, but clearly… what comes next can only be done by me.”

“Gatekeeper?” The priest was startled and reacted at once. “You want to go in alone?! Wait, it is far too unsafe. There is something very wrong with this wall. If you rush in now, you might…”

“Our city-state is being swallowed by thick fog. The Twisted Beings in the mist have no mercy. The power behind them will not wait for us to finish finding the truth before it moves,” Agatha said as she slowly shook her head. Her voice was as calm and steady as always. “Governor Winston’s team finally reached this place, yet his body is not here. Now it seems that these fallen guards held out to the last more to delay time in the tunnels… If

I am not wrong, they were buying time for the Governor to pass through this wall."

The priest did not know how to answer at first. After a few seconds of silence, he spoke on instinct: "But it is still too dangerous for you to go alone. At the very least, we should report this to the Cathedral…"

"There is no time, truly no time," Agatha said as she turned around, slowly but firmly shaking her head. As she spoke, she again felt that cold that wrapped her whole body and sank into her bones. She almost clearly felt her blood slowly stop flowing, and the matter that made up her body lose its life. The discomfort only lasted a short moment, but it still made her tone even firmer: "I must find out the secret of this mine. In the last bit of time that may be left, this might be the only thing I can…"

She suddenly stopped. She forced her thoughts and words to a halt and did her best to smooth her face back to calm. Then she looked seriously at the subordinates in front of her.

"I will pass through this wall. You know the power of a Gatekeeper. You do not need to worry about me. You have your own tasks. After I go through, you are to turn back at once and return along the route to the last junction. Then the first and second teams will continue to the excavation area as planned and find out the real situation in the Boiling Gold tunnels. The third and fourth teams will return to the surface and report what happened here to the Cathedral. Then…"

She paused for a few seconds, as if her thoughts suddenly broke off. Then she waved her hand and said: "That is all. For the rest, follow Bishop Ivan's orders."

The Guardian, the priest, and the Nuns could not help looking at one another. It was the first time they had seen the Gatekeeper act like this, and they could not help feeling uneasy and at a loss. But under Agatha's

unusually serious gaze, and with the professional discipline that long training had turned into instinct, obedience to orders became their natural response.

“Yes, we have received the order,” the leading priest said with solemn care as he nodded. He drew the Triangular Sigil of Bartok over his chest, then could not help asking: “When do you need us to come and meet you?”

“…There is no need. But do not worry, I will come back. No matter what happens, ‘I’ will come back.”

The priest stepped back. No one heard the faint, subtle change in her tone when she spoke the word “I.”

Agatha let out a slow breath and walked toward the dark wall.

Just before she touched it, she spoke softly one last time, as if whispering to someone, yet also as if speaking to herself:

“To be honest… I really do like this world…”

She stepped forward without hesitation. Her body slipped into the “stone wall” without the slightest hindrance, like one phantom merging into another.

For an instant, faint ripples appeared on the surface of the wall, but they vanished completely before anyone could see them clearly.

Darkness. Cold. No support, no way to tell up from down or left from right. Then all her senses seemed to vanish at once, only to return to her in a slow and strange way. This was all that Agatha felt after she crossed the wall.

She did not know how much time passed before she opened her “eyes” in the dark, only to find that she still could not see anything around her.

Everywhere she looked was endless chaos. Faint clumps of darkness crawled slowly across an even darker background. They looked like some

sticky, disgusting fluid, and also like huge, nameless beasts slowly creeping along.

Why was it so dark? Had she not brought a consecrated lantern when she came?

The question rose in Agatha's mind. Almost as soon as she thought it, a glimmer of light really appeared before her eyes.

The faint light lit up the area around her. She saw that she was floating in boundless black mist. Countless vague shapes crawled and flowed all around her, yet they made no sound.

Agatha watched this scene in silence, then lowered her head.

Her body came into her sight. First her torso, then her hands and feet, and then the combat Gatekeeper's cane that had been with her for many years.

"Ah… you are here too…"

Agatha spoke in a soft murmur. She slowly raised the Gatekeeper's cane in her hand and looked at the familiar patterns on it, and at the name she had carefully carved there when she first received this cane as a Guardian.

"Are you also a shadow, just like me?" she asked the Gatekeeper's cane in a soft voice.

Of course, the Gatekeeper's cane did not answer her. But in the darkness, something else suddenly made a sound.

"Bang!"

It was a gunshot.

Agatha frowned at once, but before she could look toward the source of the sound, a voice that sounded a bit tense reached her ears first: "Who is there?!"

In the darkness, Agatha turned her head. Almost at the same time, she saw a sudden glimmer of light in the direction of the voice.

A small patch of solid ground appeared there, lit by an old-style brass consecrated lantern. On the open ground she could see something like a tree stump. A middle-aged man in a dark blue coat leaned against the stump, looking like a motionless statue.

As Agatha's gaze fell on him, the "statue" suddenly moved. He jerked his head up and looked toward Agatha with surprise and tension: "Who is there?!"

Agatha felt a faint sense that something was off, but she soon put it aside. She walked toward the patch of ground lit by the consecrated lantern and saw the middle-aged man's face clearly.

It was no surprise at all. He was the Governor of the city-state of Frostholm, Mr. Winston.

"It seems you have been here for a long time, Governor," Agatha said calmly. "Now there are only the two of us left here."

"Gatekeeper… Lady Agatha?" Winston lifted his head slowly. He moved like a wind-up Doll that had worn down badly, and even his words came out slow. But as time passed, his speech and expression slowly grew more lively and smooth. "You came as well… Wait, how are you here?"

"I passed through a wall, a wall deep in the Boiling Gold mine," Agatha said in a calm voice. She knew there was no need for any more hiding or circling around. "The Guard Corps you brought has been wiped out in the tunnels, Governor. Do you still remember them?"

"The Guard Corps… oh, the Guard Corps I brought," Winston said, frowning as if he had only just remembered. Then a hint of sorrow entered

his voice. “They were all fine people. They did their best so that I could use the key left by the Queen, but I…”

Agatha’s expression changed at once: “The key left by the Queen?”

Chapter 421: Driving Toward the Abyss

“The key left by the Queen?”

Agatha’s expression changed at once. She fixed her eyes on Governor Winston.

But he looked even more surprised than she was. Winston’s eyes were full of shock: “You do not know? Then how did you come into this place?”

Agatha’s face grew serious. She realized the situation was not quite what she had imagined. When she first noticed that she could “enter” the stone wall, she had thought that Governor Winston, who came here before her, was the same kind of being as she was. But now it seemed that the Governor had used some other means.

He held more secrets than she had expected.

“I had my own way,” Agatha said slowly, and her tone carried a pressure she did not intend. “You just mentioned ‘the key left by the Queen.’ What exactly is it?”

Winston looked at the Gatekeeper with doubt, but after a moment of hesitation he let out a sigh of relief and reached into the pocket at his chest.

“Very well. We have already come this far. There is no need to keep secrets anymore.”

He took a small object from his pocket. It was a brass key with rich patterns on it. The handle of the key looked like a sideways “8,” or the infinity symbol in mathematics. Its head did not have the usual teeth of a common key, but was a short round rod with grooves.

Agatha studied the thing in his hand with interest. Suddenly she felt that it did not look like a key for opening doors at all, but rather like the kind of thing used to wind up a Doll or other clockwork device.

“A clockwork key?” she said before she could stop herself. “You mean this was left by Queen Ray Nora? Why is it in your hands as Governor?”

“The Governors passed it down from one to the next. This key is the gift the Queen left to the rebels, and also… the curse,” Winston said, pulling at the corner of his mouth in a bitter smile that even held a trace of fear. “From the moment the first Governor took the key, the Shadows behind Frostholm have hung over our heads, Gatekeeper.”

Agatha did not interrupt the weak-looking middle-aged man as he rambled on like someone muttering in his sleep. She waited patiently until he finished, then spoke in a calm tone: “You actually know the true situation of the Boiling Gold mine, do you not?”

“If you mean that the Boiling Gold mine already showed signs of drying up in the Queen’s time… yes, I knew,” Winston said with a soft sigh, speaking openly. “I am sorry. I knew from the very beginning what was going on with the door you found. But I thought there was still time, that I could set everything back on track before the situation grew worse. If that had worked, what you found would have been just an abandoned tunnel, and Frostholm… would still be the prosperous Frostholm it used to be.”

“I need an explanation, Governor,” Agatha said, her face serious and her tone a little cold. “If the Boiling Gold mine already ran dry in the Queen’s time, then what have we been digging up and shipping out for these past

decades? And what is the link between the mine's exhaustion and the Visions in the city-state today, and the actions of those cultists?"

"Boiling Gold is still Boiling Gold, Gatekeeper. What we dug up was Boiling Gold. What we shipped out was also Boiling Gold, true and solid," Winston said, lifting his head with a face that looked half like a smile and half like a grimace. "It is not some corruption. We tested it, and they also tested it in the Queen's time. If something looks like Boiling Gold, is used as Boiling Gold, and its effects and byproducts are no different from normal Boiling Gold, then without a doubt it should be Boiling Gold."

"All of that really was Boiling Gold?!" Agatha opened her eyes wide. This answer was especially hard for her to imagine. "But the mine dried up decades ago. The ore now appearing in the tunnels…"

"That is exactly what is most terrifying and strange, is it not?" Winston said with a bitter smile. "The vein ran dry, yet soon new ore would fill certain corners where no one's gaze ever reached. It was as if there were a false Frostholm, a city-state parallel to the Mortal Realm, pouring ore into our Mortal Realm world without end. Or rather… once the mine reached a certain depth, we were always mining from a mirror world world. Yet once those phantom, unreasonable things were dug out, no matter how we tested them, they all turned out to be real."

Agatha listened with a stern face. These unbelievable truths crashed into her mind, which had already often felt hazy in recent days. But she still kept her calm and spoke in a low voice: "mirror world Frostholm… Governor, you are right. There really is a mirror world Frostholm. The fog now covering the city-state, and the replicas that appear again and again in the mist, all come from that mirror world city. That mirror world city-state is slowly Corrupting and replacing our Mortal Realm world."

Winston's expression changed slightly. Then he stayed silent for more than ten seconds before finally letting out a long sigh: "Ah, so this is the price for all that Boiling Gold."

"Price? You make that word sound too light. It is not only you and me paying the price now, but everyone in the city-state, and most of them do not even know what is happening…"

"But most of them enjoy everything that the Boiling Gold trade brings. In this city of extreme cold, it is Boiling Gold that lets everyone have warm homes and enough food. It is Boiling Gold that lets us keep a fairly rich standard of life even after the sea cliffs collapsed, Gatekeeper," Winston said.

Winston paused for a few seconds at this point, then waved his hand.

"You should know this. I am never extravagant. I own no houses and keep no private wealth. I do not even have an heir. Lady, everything I have done was not for my own desire."

Agatha used her gaze on the Governor's eyes, but deep within them she saw only weariness.

"None of them had any choice…"

She spoke in a low voice, almost as if talking to herself.

"It is that no one has any choice," Winston said, shaking his head. "I know what you mean. The road we walk today, the price we pay today, was not chosen by the citizens of the city-state. But it was not chosen by me either. No one had any other path to take.

"The city-state is only so big. There is no second Frostholm on the Boundless Sea where we can stand. We need food, fuel, houses, and clean fresh water. We need Boiling Gold, even if it comes from a strange world of Shadows. Without Boiling Gold, in only one winter a quarter of the city-

state would die. In a few years, the rest would go back step by step to the dark Age of City-States before the boom of industry, and we would go on losing a quarter or even more of our people…”

“Gatekeeper, rest a while. You are as tired as I am. Perhaps now we should accept one fact. The city-state is a steam locomotive driving toward the abyss, and everyone is sitting on it. The only difference between a Guardian of the City-State and an ordinary person is that the ordinary folk live, eat, and drink with their eyes covered, while we… keep our eyes open.”

Agatha paid no attention to Winston’s despairing speech. She simply stood there in the darkness without a word, feeling that unbearable cold spread toward her again from all around, feeling the blood in her veins slowly grow cold.

Then she broke the silence: “There was someone who made another choice.”

“…Yes, there was one. The people of Frostholm once called her ‘the Queen,’ and the history books call her the ‘mad Queen,’” Winston said with a laugh, though it was hard to tell whether he was laughing at the Queen or at himself. “A great Mortal. She even wanted to fight this sea itself, to fight the horror at the very bottom of the sea.”

“The Abyssal Trench Project…” Agatha said softly. All the clues she had gathered in the past finally came together in her mind, forming a clear path. “So the Abyssal Trench Project was not just a simple exploration plan like the records say… The Queen wanted to uncover the secret hidden deep beneath the city-state?!”

“We never knew why she thought the Boiling Gold that kept appearing in the mine was linked to the Deep Sea. But clearly she had found the right direction. The runaway state of the Abyssal Trench Project and the terrible fate she later faced prove that she had touched the true source. That is the

most ironic thing about our world," Winston said. He shifted his position beside the stump and raised his head to look at the endless chaos and crawling Shadows above. He spoke slowly: "Truth points to madness. Madness points to failure. Every step you take toward your goal is a step toward the abyss."

Winston let out a sigh.

"She wanted to find out the truth of the Boiling Gold mine. She wanted to solve the hidden danger behind the city-state. She wanted to use her own wisdom and strength to fight the sea itself… all of that was good. But in the end, it only proved that she used up her fate ahead of time."

"So you 'successors' decided not to walk her old path. You pretend to cover your eyes like everyone else and rush toward the abyss with this train, while the Queen who once tried to hit the brakes or change the tracks is written in the history books as a Madman bewitched by Subspace."

"An old rule of Frostholm: the dead must make way for the living," Winston said as he slowly turned his eyes to look at Agatha with his gaze. "If the way she is judged can help Frostholm quickly return to calm after turmoil, then a ruler who was once great would not mind, I think."

Agatha wanted to say something, but in the end no words came out.

After a long time, she could only shake her head gently.

"That key… how did it end up in the hands of the first Governor?"

Chapter 422: What Was Seen in the Dark

How had The key ended up in the hands of the first Governor?

That was the question Agatha cared about most at this moment. In every record of history, whether from the viewpoint of the Queen's supporters or from the viewpoint of The authority that ruled the city-state now, all descriptions of the "uprising" or "rebellion" fifty years ago agreed on one thing: there had been an irreconcilable conflict between the Frostholm Queen and the rebels.

They had been enemies, with no chance for understanding or cooperation, let alone any kind of shared "legacy". So how had The key of Queen Ray Nora ended up in the hands of the city-state's Governor? And why had Winston called it both "The curse" and a "gift"?

As she thought quickly, Agatha lowered her head and fixed Winston with her gaze: "So there was another truth behind the uprising back then—did the Frostholm Queen and the rebels plan it together…?"

"There was no twist that dramatic, Lady Gatekeeper," Winston said. "Although it does sound like a good story. A mad City Lord and a Rebel Commander who understand each other, using a great uprising that ends the old chaos to pass on power and duty. Playwrights and novelists would love it. But sadly, real history held no such warmth.

"The great uprising was bound to happen. The rift between the mad Queen and the people of Frostholm could not be healed. She had once been great,

but her failure in the Abyssal Trench Project pushed the city-state to the edge of collapse. The first Governor raised troops against the Queen to let more people live. From the very start, there was no room for peaceful talks between them.

“But you were right about one thing. There really was a kind of ‘tacit understanding’ between the Queen and the rebels. The Queen knew that being overthrown was her unavoidable end. The rebels also knew that her madness was not as simple as ‘losing her mind’. She must have had many secrets.

“So, on the night before the execution, the Rebel Commander, who later became the first Governor, went to see the imprisoned Queen. He wanted to learn what she was hiding.

“So the Queen gave him The key and told him: after the execution, after her life ended, the one holding The key would naturally come to know everything.”

Winston stopped. A mocking yet helpless look came over his face. He lowered his head and stared at the brass key in his hand. After a long time, he gave a bitter smile and said: “Do you know what her last words to the Rebel Commander were? The history books never record them. Only the Governors of each generation know this line.

“‘I did my best. If you think you can do better, fine. Now it’s your turn.’ Those were the words she spoke after the first Governor took The key from her.”

“…Every choice had a price.” After hearing this unknown piece of history, Agatha let out a quiet sigh.

“Lady Gatekeeper,” Winston suddenly raised his head. With a strange smile, he lifted the brass key. “Do you want to try? Take The key, and look at the

sights Ray Nora once saw?”

Agatha suddenly hesitated. She stared hard at The key Winston held out to her. Her heart, which had been beating slow and sluggish, began to pound again. A heavy pressure spread from The key, as if half a century of darkness and malice had gathered inside it. Yet after a few seconds of silence and doubt, she still took a soft breath and reached out her hand toward The key.

A faint, icy chill came from her fingertips.

In the next second, countless phantoms surged out of endless darkness. Broken flashes of light and shadow swept in like a storm and flooded Agatha’s mind. In that wild rush of information, scenes began to flash one after another inside her head—

In the endless darkness of The Deep Sea, some huge and terrifying limb of shadow slowly grew and spread.

An ancient, chilling gaze looked toward the city-state from The Deep Sea, sweeping over the living world with the cold indifference of an indescribable Elder God.

Dark and dreadful matter overflowed from The Deep Sea and rose upward. It formed a replica of the Mortal Realm. As illusion and reality shifted, that matter sometimes became Shadows, sometimes turned solid. The boundless Deep Sea was packed full of filthy, chaotic figures, crowding together and lifting their empty eyes toward the city-state.

Farther away, in even deeper and darker waters, the whole world—the entire Boundless Sea, and the seabed beneath hundreds and thousands of city-states—lay in vague, shadowy shapes, as if an ancient world had sunk into that endless darkness. Abominations grew from the old corpses there, rising and rising without end…

And in the depths of these countless visions, Agatha always felt a kind of “gaze”. It was not a single look, not any will with a clear source. She felt as if time itself were staring at her. Something older than history, larger than the city-state, as if it came from the deepest part of this world… was gazing at her.

There was no feeling in that gaze, no malice and no kindness. It simply gazed. It was like a hollow shell, without a soul, looking at an uninvited guest who had stumbled into Truth, and saying calmly—

“Oh. You have come.”

Boom!

Agatha felt a loud crash in the depths of her mind. The last of her reason forced her to struggle upward through the layers of visions. In that process, her senses and thoughts were pressed to the limit. She could feel more information and more fragments of thought swirling around her. Some of them might even have held the will or words left behind by Queen Ray Nora. But she could neither see them clearly nor understand them.

When she finally took back control of her body, all the visions were gone. She opened her eyes in the dark chaos and saw the Governor, Winston, still in front of her, even holding the brass key out to her in the same pose as before—as if only a single second had passed.

She was back in this strange, crawling darkness again… Wait, no. Something had changed!

Agatha suddenly noticed something strange in her field of vision. She lifted her head in alarm and looked around.

The darkness in all directions seemed to have faded compared to before. The shapeless black things that had been slowly squirming and changing now seemed to be gathering and forming real shapes. Between illusion and

reality, she saw many things spreading and growing out of the surrounding space from nothing. They looked like dry tree branches, yet they filled the whole space in dense layers. The black “branches” connected and joined in the void. Faint sparks of light ran along them, like…

like express dispatch capsules racing through steam pipes.

Deep inside this complex, bramble-like network of “branches”, through layers and layers of phantoms, Agatha saw a massive… limb.

It was a thick limb like a tentacle. Its huge size was like a pillar holding up the sky and earth. Its surface was covered in dull blue lines. The patterns formed by those lines looked like countless eyes.

[Mental corruption? An illusion? madness threshold?]

Countless thoughts flashed through Agatha’s mind. She shut her eyes at once, but the pillar that seemed to hold up the world still remained in her sight. She tried to offer a Prayer to the God of Death and to steady her will with divine magic, yet she found that her mind was clear. There were no signs of corruption at all.

After several quick emergency measures all failed, she realized one thing—

She was not mad. While fully awake and sane, she had seen a “view” whose place she did not know, and whose reality she could not be sure of.

She stood there inside this vast and terrifying “view”, almost unable to think, until the Governor, Winston, pulled her back with his voice: “Oh. Looks like you saw it.”

The middle-aged Governor slowly lifted his head as he spoke and sighed softly: “Magnificent, isn’t it?”

Agatha hesitated and looked down. Only then did she notice that what Winston was “leaning against” was not a tree stump at all. It was actually

part of the huge branch structure around them, a piece that extended out from the branches. Above it were faint black structures that stretched all the way into the deepest part of this strange space.

“These… these branches…”

“This is the Elder Gods’ thoughts, made visible in the eyes of Mortals like us,” Winston said calmly. “You only touched The key for the first time, so you can see very little. But I have lived with this key day and night for more than ten years… What it has told me goes far beyond what you can imagine.”

Agatha felt as if she were falling into a dream. She slowly grasped Winston’s words and repeated without thinking: “The Elder Gods’… thoughts?”

“Hard to believe, isn’t it? These branch-like things are not truly there. What you are seeing is likely just a single thought that passed through the God’s mind for a moment. That thought burned itself into this place and became the huge structure you see. Oh, and don’t try to decipher anything from it. Don’t try to understand the pattern of those lights. You will go mad.”

Agatha turned her head sharply: “Someone went mad because of this?”

“Of course,” Winston said with a laugh. “Did you forget? Her name was Ray Nora…”

Agatha had no words for a moment. After a few seconds, she spoke softly: “Then… what is that thing outside the ‘thicket’?”

“The Abyssal Lord,” Winston said quietly. “A small part of It. The part that has pierced into the city-state.”

Chapter 423: Moving Forward

It was the deep, dark sea floor beneath the city-state. The Elder Gods had stretched Their tendrils into the Mortal Realm, and in that unspeakable darkness They grew stronger day by day—

It was visible. Those foul and terrifying tentacles of flesh were Its body: cold and chilling. Yet It was also formless, because Its will that spread upward had already crossed the dark sea trench and pierced the thick rock and soil beneath the city-state. For the past fifty years, or even longer, Its unimaginable power had been drilling into this city and stabbing deep into the Boiling Gold mine.

“Lady Gatekeeper, we are now inside It,” Winston said. “This was once rock. But the power of the Elder Gods has transformed the rock into part of Its flesh. This dark substance beats together with the source on the seabed, through more than a thousand meters of stone and seawater. With every throb, it pulls that mirror world city-state a little closer to our Mortal Realm… Do you hear it? Thump, thump… Flesh is squirming, tightening, dreaming. This place… is thinking.”

Winston murmured like a Prayer and slowly raised both arms, as if to embrace the endless darkness around them and the branch-like structures that crossed and joined like a thorny thicket. Between those branches, dim points of light darted like fireflies. Little by little, Agatha really seemed to hear that low sound—thump, thump…

This Anomaly, buried deep inside the Boiling Gold mine and spread over who knew how wide an area, was giving off the sound of a heartbeat.

Even her own heart seemed to be affected by that heartbeat, ready to beat in time with it.

But a faint warmth suddenly rose in her chest and snapped Agatha awake. She realized that her human mind had just stepped back from the edge of madness. Her expression changed at once, and she stared hard into Winston's eyes.

"Your mind is already unsound, Governor Winston—you have been affected by this place."

"Ah… is it?" Winston waved his hand as if it did not matter. "Maybe. At first I thought I could, like the Queen, calm this Elder God again. Then I thought I could at least slow it down for a while. After that I thought I could at least stay sane until the end. So in the end… I have already failed without even noticing?"

"Calm this Elder God, like the Queen did?" Agatha caught the key point in the Governor's words. Her eyes changed at once as she faintly realized the real reason he had come here. "You mean that fifty years ago, the Frostholm Queen really did manage to put the power of the Abyssal Lord to sleep?"

Winston smiled: "What do you think caused the sea cliff to collapse back then?"

Agatha froze for a moment before speaking in doubt: "The sea cliff collapse… After the Queen was decapitated, the whole execution ground fell into the sea… That wasn't an accident?!"

"It was a sacrificial rite. The main sacrificial victim was the Queen herself, along with the first group of opportunists who chose to betray her after the uprising began. Of course, the whole execution squad and many rebel officers were buried with her as well," Winston said calmly. "We sealed the detailed records from that time, so few people know what really happened

after the sea cliff collapsed. Thousands died in that ‘accident’, but in fact, almost all the commoners survived. Those who were swept into the waves… even if they were only one meter from the shore, had no chance to struggle. They were ‘pulled’ straight down to the seabed.

“After that collapse, the Anomaly inside the Boiling Gold mine stopped expanding for a time. Only then did the first Governor realize that everything had been part of Ray Nora’s plan. The cold truth passed to the Governor through The key left by the Queen. Just as she said, it was now our turn.”

Agatha fell silent. After a moment, her eyes grew complicated: “You came here to recreate that sacrificial rite…”

“It is rising,” Winston said. “The knowledge carried in The key tells me that to slow this process, you must touch Its mind. Fifty years ago, Its power still slept in The Deep Sea, so the Queen could only offer herself to The Deep Sea as a sacrifice. But now Its power has already stabbed deep into the city-state, so this is the best place to reach It. This was the method the Queen left inside The key. Every Governor who took The key became tied to this duty and spent their whole life preparing for it. I prepared everything as well. Only one thing… I failed to account for.”

Winston pulled at the corner of his mouth. It barely counted as a smile.

“Not everyone is Ray Nora.”

Agatha listened in silence. Then she lowered her head and quietly gazed at the brass key lying in her palm.

This was something the Frostholm Queen had created with some kind of supernatural power. She had taken the “knowledge” she had touched and a part of her own “thoughts” and condensed them into The key in physical form.

But for some reason, Agatha kept feeling that The key should have other uses.

It should not exist only to tie all the later rulers of Frostholm to a burden of duty.

But the Governor, Winston, was clearly unable to answer any more of her questions now. And she herself seemed to have no way back.

After learning the truth of this dark space, Agatha understood one thing. She had not passed through a stone wall to reach some location. Instead, she herself had been merged directly into a huge mass of Anomalous matter.

What waited for Winston here was death. What waited for her was return and assimilation.

She looked at her palm. The skin that touched The key had already begun to soften and warp. Thick black substance seeped from her skin and slowly covered The key.

But she still wanted to go farther. She was… curious about this place.

“Is there anything else we can do?” Agatha lowered her head and looked at the silent Governor of the city-state. “Are you going to stay here and wait for death to come?”

“Death has already come, Lady,” Winston said, shaking his head. “We are only looking back on our failed lives before we breathe our last. There is nothing left to do. Sit down and rest, like me.”

“You have already done what you should,” Agatha said calmly. “As Frostholm’s Governor, you at least faced this so-called ‘curse’ bravely. Falling short does not mean you did nothing.”

But Winston only shrugged at himself: “Incompetence is a sin.”

“I will keep going,” Agatha said. “I want to pass through this ‘thicket’ and go to where that tentacle is. Will you come with me?”

“It no longer means anything to me, Lady,” Winston replied softly. “If you wish to go, then go. Leave me here. My road has already ended.”

Agatha stared at him for a few seconds, then held out the brass key: “This is yours.”

Winston did not reach for it. He lifted his head and looked into Agatha’s eyes: “Keep it. You have already taken it. Now it is yours. This is how we have passed it down until now.”

Agatha fell silent for a moment, then put The key away.

“All right. Then I will go on alone.”

She said farewell to Winston, turned around, and propped herself up with her Gatekeeper’s cane as she took a step forward in this dark, empty space.

“Lady Agatha,” Winston’s voice suddenly came from behind her. “Does this really mean anything?”

Agatha turned her head slightly: “Why do you ask?”

“Even if you learn more truth ahead,” Winston said, “even if you really pass through this ‘forest’ and touch that limb of the Elder God—what can you change? You can no longer stop any of this. You cannot even pass what happens here to the outside world. The investigation is over. If you cannot pass on information, no matter how much you know, it is meaningless.”

Agatha stopped walking. After a moment’s thought, she spoke softly: “I am Frostholm’s Gatekeeper. This is my duty. And besides…”

She paused. The hand that held the brass key pressed against her chest without her noticing.

It was still cold all around. The feeling of her blood slowly freezing was stronger than ever. But for some reason, ever since just now she had felt a faint warmth beating in her chest, as if an unseen flame were flickering there, supporting her as she walked forward.

In her mind, thoughts that did not belong to her fluttered softly. The strongest among them was a stubborn will. It pointed straight toward the huge, unreal tentacle beyond this thicket.

“It does have meaning. I am not walking forward alone. I have no proof, but I think… everything I see here will be known by someone, in the end.”

“Oh, is that so? That is good then… Lady Agatha, it is truly enviable that you still hold to your faith even at the last moment.”

Winston’s voice fell silent. Nothing more came from that direction.

Agatha turned back and saw a small consecrated lantern shining in the darkness. It lit up a dry “tree stump”, where a middle-aged man in a dark blue coat was quietly leaning.

A bullet hole had pierced his temple, and in his lowered hand he held a finely crafted revolver.

Chapter 424: The ritual Site

Now, she was the only one left here.

Agatha slowly drew her gaze back from the consecrated lantern. She turned around, leaving Governor Winston in that chilly, quiet darkness, and stepped toward the “branches” that crisscrossed the endless space, toward the gigantic thorny curtain that hung like the vault of the sky.

A dim consecrated lantern hung at her waist. In her right hand she held the Gatekeeper’s cane that had been with her in her memories for many years. Her left hand still gripped the brass key from Winston. The key was no longer icy cold. It now held a warmth like body heat, as if it were slowly fusing with her body.

But Agatha no longer paid attention to what was happening to her body.

She simply walked in the darkness, feeling this body truly moving forward. As long as the surrounding chaos had not completely swallowed and assimilated her, she still had to keep going.

She groped for footing in the void, and every time she stepped, ground like a narrow path appeared in the darkness. She searched for a way out among the thorns. Between the branches that wove across each other, narrow openings sometimes let her squeeze through.

The sharp “thorns” soon tore her clothes. The dense “fabric” was as fragile as loose ash and mist before the stabbing thoughts of the Elder Gods. The falling scraps gathered in the dark into writhing black droplets and sank into the path under her feet. From time to time she also brushed the sparks that

leapt and darted between the thorns. Whenever she touched those flashes, she could clearly feel something boring into her mind.

They were the thoughts of the Elder Gods, a murmur from the Abyssal Lord. There was no malice in it, not even a complete intent. But to a weak mortal, even that briefest spark of thought was dazzling and blinding, like a great brilliant candle in the night.

Another dim flash shot over from afar, sliding along the pitch-black thorny branches across her vision. A strand of Agatha's hair brushed that light, and in a hundredth of a second new "knowledge" surfaced in her mind—

111010011001101110000110……111001111011111010100100……

Agatha could not understand the message these sparks tried to convey to her. Just as Winston had told her, she must not try to guess at the thoughts of the Elder Gods.

It would drive her mad.

She lifted her head.

The grand structure of dead wood and thorns that bridged the void filled her sight. Countless dim lights fluttered among the thickets like fireflies. A thin mist shrouded the outside of the thorn barrier, and in the depths of that fog the vast limbs of the Abyssal Lord swayed slightly, like an invitation.

The air grew cold again—sharper and more piercing than before. The chill carried dampness and seeped into her body as if it meant to freeze her bones.

Agatha instinctively clutched the front of her clothes, only to realize that at some point they had become tattered. The thorns along the way had left countless wounds of all sizes on her skin.

In those wounds, foul, thick black fluid crawled slowly like blood.

But just when she thought the cold would completely devour her, a faint warm heat rose once more from her chest…

…

A small green flame burned quietly on Agatha’s chest. Its eerie green light lit her face and the cold, damp sewer around her.

All sensation seemed to drift far away, or be separated from her reason by a thick Veil. The warmth in her veins seemed to fade with time, and with it faded the fatigue and pain she had built up along the way.

Agatha slowly shook her head, trying to drive out the numbness filling her mind. As her vision swayed, something strange suddenly appeared at the edge of her sight.

She saw the dim, cramped sewer corridor ahead suddenly seem to widen. A thin mist rose in the hazy space, and shapes like branches or thickets of thorns appeared within the fog and slowly crept toward her.

Yet in the next second, the illusory scene vanished like smoke. All she saw was the same dark corridor.

And the gate at the end of it.

Thump… thump…

The instant her gaze fell on that gate, an unreal heartbeat seemed to sound by Agatha’s ear, as if a huge heart hid behind the door, beating and swelling in the dark.

Agatha’s dulled, numb mind suddenly rallied, and her gaze snapped to that door.

“Ah… I found you…”

She closed her hand around the little flame and stepped into the darkness. The almost-broken combat Gatekeeper's cane supported her one last time. Her pace grew faster and even began to stir the air. She advanced into the darkness and left it behind her, while the low, terrifying heartbeat pounded against her chest like heavy drumbeats and even hammered in her head.

Gradually she heard something else mixed into that heartbeat. It sounded like hundreds and thousands of people in benediction, chanting, calling out to some dark and unnameable being.

She no longer cared how much noise was tangled in those mingled voices. She was about to deliver the Fire Seed. The lair of those heretics lay in the deepest place ahead.

The Gatekeeper's cane and her heels struck the ground in a rapid rhythm.

Just then Agatha heard another sound—not her own steps, nor the heartbeat and massed benediction echoing from the depths.

It was other footsteps, a whole crowd. The dense tread sounded as if it came from another direction—very close to this corridor, but separated by a wall or two.

Gunshots came with the footsteps. They were from large-caliber rifles.

Other people? Living people? Were there still others moving through this city of mirror world with her?!

Questions flashed through Agatha's mind, but they did not slow her at all. In almost an instant she rushed across the last stretch before the gate and came to the great door from which the heartbeat sounded.

The door stood slightly ajar, and within the crack was darkness so thick it almost clotted. The darkness seemed solid as it seeped and flowed out.

But this was exactly what Agatha had been seeking all along.

She braced her shoulder against the heavy door and pushed it open with all her strength.

With a long creak, the door opened.

A vast darkness appeared before Agatha—or rather, some boundless Shadows had shrouded what had once been ordinary space, leaving only darkness in her view.

She could only just make out that the darkness seemed to be an assembly hall. The widest junction of the sewers had been turned into a sacrificial rite and a place to nurture the Elder Gods. Countless vague, formless things writhed in the dark. Their malice rushed at her like a stench.

Before she could react, a sharp whoosh sounded in the nearby darkness. Something was striking at her. At the same time, a familiar, hateful voice rang out from the distant ritual field, full of mockery and scorn:

“Ah, the last sacrificial victim has finally arrived—and how nice, the other you has just reached the appointed place as well.”

“Bang!”

The Gatekeeper’s cane swept out, bursting into a brief, bright spark in the darkness. A twisted, hideous limb was struck off in midair and fell at Agatha’s feet. The impact almost knocked her over. When she barely regained her balance, she lifted her head at once and looked toward the source of the voice.

She could only barely see the tall, thin figure of a young man standing at the far end of the darkness.

He spread his arms toward her.

“Come then, sacrificial victim. Your arrival is a part of the plan—now it is time to build the passage.”

Agatha leaned on the Gatekeeper’s cane and slowly lifted her head through the weakness and dizziness: “You are bringing ruin on yourselves…”

“Yes, we will all die here. But that does not matter. As long as you step in here, the ritual has already succeeded—I admit, it really is a trap.”

…

A gunshot cracked. The muzzle flash and explosion tore through the dim corridor. The powerful round blew the head off a twisted monster with three eyes. Its mutated, hideous body fell to the ground, then quickly melted and collapsed into nauseating black sludge.

Yet more howls from monsters rose all around, and more twisted entities kept pouring out—from the surrounding walls, from the pipes, from the drains, even from the cracks in the dome above.

Mud-like matter seeped and flowed from every gap visible to the naked eye, turning into countless monsters that only vaguely resembled humans.

“I think we did not bring enough bullets!”

A sailor shouted, quickly swapping magazines, lifting his rifle, and firing. His shout mingled with the crackle of ghostly flames burning on him, making his voice sound hoarse and low.

Lawrence had no time to answer the sailor. A sudden rush of wind came from behind his head. He only had time to twist slightly aside to avoid the deadly blow, then, driven by instinct, he reached back and grabbed.

He yanked a humanoid monster over from behind him. It wore a city-state Guard Corps uniform from decades ago and held a saber in its hand. It crashed hard onto the floor.

Lawrence stepped forward and stomped hard on the replica freak’s chest. The ghostly flames on his body flared up at once. The spreading fire burned

that not-quite-human monster to ash in almost an instant.

In the next second, Lawrence, wreathed in ghostly flames, lifted his head and looked down the corridor that seemed to stretch on forever.

Everywhere he looked was filled with blasphemous, twisted things.

Chapter 425: The Last Queen’s Guard Corps

The enemies had appeared suddenly after the team entered a corridor that led straight into the depths of the darkness—and there seemed to be no end to their numbers.

A sharp whoosh cut through the air beside him as a curved blade swung at his neck from a vicious angle. At the last possible moment, Lawrence leaned back and grabbed the arm holding the blade. Ghostly green flames surged up from the edge of his palm and burned a monster in a navy uniform whose head was split vertically into ashes. Before he could react, several gunshots rang out from ahead.

The shots came from a crawling monster that had suddenly climbed out of a drain. The monster had an upper body like a human’s, but its lower half was nothing but heaving piles of tissue like warped internal organs. It clutched a “rifle” that looked as if it were pieced together from bone and flesh, yet the muzzle of that obviously wrong creation spat fire.

Lawrence’s gaze sharpened at once. Time around him seemed to slow. In that instant he felt his sight grow sharper than that of ordinary people by countless times. He could even see clearly the bullets’ path as they flew toward him. In the next moment he twisted his body and dodged the bullets coming at him with impossible angles and movements.

He dodged three times and got hit by six rounds.

“You damned monsters!” The intense pain hit, and the old captain cursed. Then he raised his revolver and fired twice at the monster.

He lowered his head and looked at his chest. Several shocking bullet holes had torn the flesh there, yet under the burning of ghostly fire the half-transparent spirit form flesh was healing at a speed visible to the naked eye.

It was not fatal, but it still caused intense pain and fatigue. The Power of Flame also seemed to be slowly draining—right now it was still full, but no one could say whether it would run out.

All around Lawrence, his fully armed subordinates were still fighting. These sailors wrapped in ghostly flames had realized their current temporary undying state, and their fighting style had grown more and more fierce. They used rifles, bayonets, and short swords to hold back the monsters that never seemed to end, while trying with all their strength to push deeper down the corridor.

Yet like Lawrence himself, none of them were used to their current spirit form state, much less able to control those ghostly flames. These sailors who had accidentally gained undying bodies were only squandering their strength and firepower. The battle in the sewer corridor had become so chaotic it was hard to even look at.

So even with bodies that could regenerate, they could only advance at an unbearably slow pace under the endless monsters’ blockade. There was no hope of breaking through.

The only one on the field not affected by the ghostly flames was the mummified corpse. Anomaly077 was also fighting. He swung two curved blades and moved through the battlefield with a speed and agility completely unlike that of a mummified corpse, charging back and forth like the wind. If his vision had not been greatly enhanced, Lawrence would have doubted he could even follow the mummified corpse’s movements.

But now his sight far surpassed that of ordinary people, so Anomaly077's speed no longer looked so outrageous to Lawrence. He could clearly see the mummified corpse slip past every fierce-looking monster, moving along the safe routes on the battlefield. The curved blades in its hands flashed up and down, and after slashing about for half an hour they were still as new as ever—the edges had not touched anything at all.

The "sailor" was only running up and down the corridor waving his two blades. The only thing louder than anyone else was his shouting.

"I will cut the path with my blades!" The mummified corpse's harsh voice echoed in the corridor, mixed with the blades' whistles through the air. "These ugly blasphemous things are no match for me!"

Lawrence strode forward and grabbed the "sailor" by the neck as he tried to charge past. His strength was shocking now; he lifted the charging mummified corpse by the throat and hauled him up to his face. His hoarse voice crackled with the sound of bursting flames: "If you cannot help, then at least be quiet for me!"

Anomaly077's dried-up head was only a few centimeters from Lawrence's face as Lawrence gripped his neck. The mummified corpse trembled all over. "Y-yes… yes… yes, Captain!"

Lawrence raised his hand and hurled the mummified corpse ten meters ahead. "Get out there and clear the way—if we do not break through today, I will stuff you into the steam core's combustion chamber!"

The mummified corpse let out a strange yell as he flew through the air and finally got tangled up with the mud-born monsters that kept pouring out. A crew member with a rifle ran up beside Lawrence and shouted, "Captain! We are almost out of bullets!"

Lawrence jerked his head around and saw that almost all the people he had brought were already fighting the monsters with cold weapons. They were relying entirely on their undying state to hold out in this corridor, but the team's overall advance had clearly stopped.

They could no longer move forward.

And there was no way back.

Chaotic shouts and the chilling sounds of flesh bursting and limbs breaking filled the corridor. Black sludge kept seeping from the walls and ceiling, and his subordinates in their spirit form bodies were almost drowned by endless monsters. The spirit form flames on their bodies still burned, but fatigue was piling up, and that tiredness was slowing and muddling even his thoughts.

In the depths of this chaotic sewer, Lawrence suddenly felt dazed. He even began to feel that the whole world was unreal.

Who was he, where was he, what was he doing… The monsters here were endless, and yet the agreed-upon midnight… how much longer would it be?

Just then, as if to answer his trance, Lawrence suddenly heard Martha's voice coming from the Pocket Mirror at his chest:

"They are here."

The old captain snapped out of his haze at once. He hurriedly raised his hand, drew a short sword from his waist, and ran through a monster lunging at him. Then he stepped back to avoid the black sludge that nearly splashed onto him and quickly looked up.

Footsteps sounded in the corridor—very, very many footsteps. With them came distant, faint shouts and calls of orders. Then these sounds rushed closer and, in almost an instant, reached the area where Lawrence and the sailors were fighting for their lives.

In the blink of an eye, countless figures appeared.

It was as if they had stepped out of days long past. One shadow after another gathered out of the air and took shape as fully armed soldiers. They gripped old-style rifles from half a century ago, and the bayonets on their muzzles gleamed coldly in the dark corridor. They charged out of the darkness toward another stretch of darkness. The forming of their bodies did not slow their charge at all, as if their battle had never stopped and only at this moment could their figures be seen.

The sailors fighting in the corridor were stunned by this sudden sight and stopped without thinking. They watched the unit charge in, watched them fire at the monsters that were everywhere here, watched them roar as they threw themselves into the fight. Several seconds passed before one sailor finally reacted and muttered in shock: “The last Queen’s Guard Corps…”

Lawrence also came back to himself. He stepped forward without thinking and walked toward a young soldier who was loading his rifle. The soldier looked at most twenty. The Old Era city-state Guard Corps uniform on him was ragged, as if he had been crawling and fighting in this sewer for a long, long time.

“Hello, we are here to hel—” Lawrence reached out to pat the young soldier on the shoulder, but his words cut off halfway.

His hand passed straight through the other man’s body.

Was this only an illusion?

Lawrence lifted his head in shock, only to see that those ghost-like soldiers were already locked in fierce battle with the monsters in the corridor. Their guns kept firing, and those inhuman things of filthy mud that only resembled people fell one after another.

A tall soldier charged in from the other side. Lawrence hurried to dodge but was too slow. He watched as the tall soldier ran straight toward him as if he could not see him, then passed through Lawrence's body like a phantom. A stray shot from a monster struck the soldier a heartbeat later, and the tall figure crashed to the floor of the sewer.

The other Queen's Guard Corps soldiers ran around the corpse and continued deeper down the corridor.

A sailor walked up beside him and muttered behind Lawrence, "They are phantoms…"

"But these phantoms can fight those monsters. They can even destroy them…" Lawrence said blankly, still feeling as if he were dreaming.

"The monsters in the corridor are not increasing anymore," another sailor said nearby.

Lawrence reacted at once.

For the first time, the number of monsters in the corridor was truly going down. After that phantom Queen's Guard Corps appeared, the black sludge that had been pouring from the walls and ceiling finally stopped seeping out. The twisted freaks that they had never been able to kill off before were now actually being reduced!

Could the existence of the Queen's Guard Corps restrain those monsters' "regeneration" and "multiplication"?

Countless questions filled Lawrence's mind, but he knew something more important than chasing those answers.

"Follow the Queen's Guard Corps!" He raised his hand high and shouted the order. "Follow the path they open!"

"Yes, Captain!"

Chapter 426: The Final Counterattack

Sounds echoed from the depths of the corridor, but they were mixed and hazy, impossible to make out.

There seemed to be the sound of cold wind, muffled whispers, dense footsteps, and gunfire.

Everything had blended together. Everything had lost its clear borders. The whole world seemed to be kneaded into a single mass. There was no front or back, no yesterday or today—just like the dim corridor ahead, choked with mist, heavy and dull as if it could swallow everything.

A hunched old man shuffled forward slowly down the corridor. The heavy wrench in his hand sometimes bumped into the pipes on the walls, making a low, strange clanging sound.

[Who am I? Where is this place? Where am I going? Why am I going there?]

[The assault had begun… Midnight, zero hour, was when the Queenguard Corps launched their attack. But what exactly were we attacking? Which way were we supposed to advance?]

Old Ghost’s foggy mind now and then produced some scattered, broken thoughts, some long-faded memories. But soon they all melted back into his muddled brain. Sometimes he felt as if he were walking on two split roads at once, his jumbled senses and memories of past experiences tangled inside

this body. Yet sometimes he felt he had never moved at all, that he had only stayed where he was, waiting in place for fifty years for orders.

The heavy wrench hit something with a clank. Old Ghost slowly lowered his head and saw that it was a helmet—black, narrow brim, marked with the sign of the Queenguard Corps. It was something from fifty years ago, something no one saw anymore.

He stared blankly at the helmet as it fell to the ground and rolled, rattling, into the drain at the side. It seemed as if something was struggling to crawl out of that drain, but it soon blended into the surrounding darkness and vanished.

He let out a vague mutter and went on walking into the dark, as if he were slowly stepping into a clump of thick black sludge. He did not know how much time passed before he finally stopped at the end of the corridor.

Crisscrossing pipes, collapsed rubble, and smoke and black matter seeping between the stones blocked the old man's way. He stopped there and looked around, confused.

He did not recognize this place. He did not even remember there being such a spot in the Second Waterway. But he still stopped here, because… there was something here waiting for him to finish.

Old Ghost lowered his head and looked at a puddle beside the rubble. His own confused eyes were reflected in the water.

[What was I supposed to do here?]

Just then, a strange scene suddenly appeared in the puddle—

soldiers of the Queenguard Corps trampled over the endless monsters swarming through the corridor. The guns and bayonets in their hands turned wave after wave of replica freaks into cold, dried sludge. Wherever they

passed, no more muck seeped from the walls, and even the darkness in the corridor seemed to thin.

Everything was just as Lawrence had guessed: the very existence of the Queenguard Corps was suppressing the corruption in this city-state of mirror world.

If everything happening in this city-state was seen as the clash of two forces, then the sludge monsters and the Queenguard Corps were clearly the two sides made flesh. This struggle and entanglement had likely gone on for half a century already.

Lawrence's marine squad ran quickly along the corridor. Following the path the Queenguard Corps had opened, they covered in a dozen minutes ground that had held them back for hours before. All the way, Lawrence kept watching and thinking.

He tried to figure out the true nature of this Queenguard Corps and even tried to communicate with these phantoms. But every attempt failed.

The Queenguard Corps could not see him. They did not even sense the presence of these uninvited guests. These soldiers were like memories projected from a distant past, mechanically repeating a battle from decades ago. They advanced, fired, fought hand to hand, and fell… and all of this had likely happened every day for decades.

The information Martha had given him about the Queenguard Corps was right, but clearly not complete.

He could not build any kind of cooperation with these "helpers".

"Captain! They can't see us. What do we do?" A sailor ran up beside Lawrence and shouted: "With just the dozen of us tagging along, it feels like we can't help at all!"

Lawrence’s expression grew complicated. He glanced down at the pocket mirror on his chest. But Martha’s voice came out of it before he could speak: “Don’t ask me. I have no idea how to handle what you’re seeing. I only knew they existed, I’ve never dealt with them myself…”

As she spoke, faint sounds of artillery came again from the mirror. Martha was clearly very busy on her side; the situation there was no simpler than in these sewers.

“Has the Queenguard Corps just been repeating this battle all these years?” Lawrence called out. “And each time the outcome is the same?!”

“Yes. The result is always the same. They appear at midnight, and fade at the next full hour. Every time, they fail to break through the obstacle at the end!”

Fail to break through the obstacle at the end?

Hearing this, Lawrence instinctively looked up toward the direction where the phantom soldiers were charging.

They were rushing toward the deepest part of the corridor. In that dark, chaotic space, thick malice churned in his senses like sludge made solid.

“I understand!” Lawrence suddenly shouted.

Martha’s voice came from the mirror: “Understand what?!”

But Lawrence no longer had time to answer the woman in the mirror. Once he faintly sensed what he needed to do, he gathered his subordinates and ran ahead faster.

At the same time, the battle in the corridor reached a fever pitch. The Queenguard Corps launched their final charge. Warriors formed from countless phantoms roared and cut down the monsters blocking their way with their weapons. Warriors kept falling, turning into bubbles that vanished

in the air, and monsters kept falling, turning into sludge that flowed into the drains on both sides. As the fierce fighting went on, the assault force finally drew close to the end of the corridor.

Lawrence finally saw the end of this brutal fight. He saw the obstacle that had blocked the Queenguard Corps for half a century—

It was a door. A huge door covered with countless clumps of brambles and filthy black mud, so dreadful in appearance it made the heart tremble.

On the surface of the door, the tangled brambles were like dead branches woven into a crown. Dim lights wandered deep in the thorns without pattern, like countless eyes hidden within them. An ordinary person would only need to glance that way to have fear and madness seize their heart.

Even Lawrence, who now served as a vessel for spirit flame, felt his mind shake and his head roar when he saw the door blocked by the thorns.

And that was the target of the Queenguard Corps' assault.

In front of the door, uncountable black sludge gathered, and countless monsters rose from the muck. They crudely mimicked human shapes. Some wore the uniforms of the city Guard Corps and the navy, some were pirates with mismatched gear or armed citizens, and there were even monster-shapes like ancient cannons and demons made from heaps of bone.

These monsters used the crude fortifications in the hall as cover and defended the thorned door like fanatical believers guarding their master.

The final battle began.

The Queenguard Corps poured all their firepower onto the monsters across the hall. The monsters' counterattack shook the entire Second Waterway. In almost the blink of an eye, both sides lost more than half their strength. Lawrence and the dozen sailors he had brought could only try their best to find cover at the edge of this deadly battlefield.

With fire that dense, even Lawrence, protected by the flame of his spirit form, did not dare bet that he truly could not die.

But he was not only hiding. He was watching.

He watched to see just how far the Queenguard Corps could go in this battle.

As the fight went on and both sides kept losing people, the defenses before the door finally weakened. The deadly cannons and demonic creatures there were torn apart, and gaps opened in the line before the thorns.

“Demolition team! Go!”

Crouched beside the Queenguard Corps’ position, Lawrence suddenly heard a shout. It was the voice of some Guard Corps commander.

An instant later, he caught sight of several figures crawling forward at the edge of the battlefield.

A squad had broken off from the main line. Using the monsters’ blind spots, they slipped into the drain along the edge of the hall and inched toward a hidden spot beside the thorned door.

At the same time, the fire from the front line suddenly grew even heavier. A storm of bullets poured out, trying to pin down and draw the attention of the monsters in front of the door.

Lawrence held his breath without thinking. Even though he knew this was likely only a phantom scene that the outside world could not change, he still did it by instinct.

But the thing he feared still happened.

The demolition team creeping along the battlefield edge toward the thorned door was discovered.

A burst of bullets tore into the drain. Several soldiers carrying explosives fell into the channel at once.

But almost at the same time, another demolition group slipped into the dark trench on the hall's other side and kept crawling toward the door covered in thorns.

They were discovered too. The second demolition team fell only a dozen meters from the thorned door.

Just then, a sailor's low cry reached Lawrence's ears: "They're about to disappear!"

Lawrence looked up at once, and the scene in the corridor filled his eyes—

The Queenguard Corps was disappearing.

After the second demolition team failed, all the Guard Corps soldiers froze for a moment. Then each of their figures began to fade and dissolve. In the blink of an eye, a third of them were already half-transparent phantoms.

Something Martha had said suddenly surfaced in Lawrence's mind:

"…Every time, they fail to break through the obstacle at the end…"

Lawrence suddenly understood what those words meant. He understood the outcome of this battle every single time: the Queenguard Corps failed. They kept fighting. They stubbornly repeated it. But the unchangeable fact was that, in this "last counterattack" at midnight, they failed.

This operation had failed fifty years ago.

Every repetition since then had only repeated that failure.

Lawrence felt dazed for a moment. But just then, from the corner of his eye, he saw another figure appear on the battlefield.

It was a figure rushing out from a corner of the hall—a phantom that had not yet begun to fade.

Lawrence and all the sailors fixed their eyes on that figure at once.

He was not a soldier, but a young man who looked like an army engineer. He wore coarse dark blue work clothes and a slanted soft cap that had been in style fifty years ago. On his belt, besides a pistol and ammo pouch, hung a big wrench.

He rushed toward the trench and toward the explosive charge the second demolition team had left behind. Then he grabbed the wooden crate full of explosives and hurriedly crawled toward the thorned door.

For a moment, Lawrence almost thought he would succeed.

But a bullet flew over. It struck the young man’s shoulder like a hammer. Half his body convulsed, and he fell just a few meters short of the thorned door.

The whole hall seemed to fall silent at once.

The last counterattack was over.

All the Queenguard Corps soldiers began to fade faster, and this scene that had repeated for fifty years returned to its starting point.

Perhaps this was also the last time it would repeat.

Lawrence, his gaze blank, stared at the young man who had fallen at the very end.

“The last of the Queenguard Corps,” the last of the fallen. His death seemed to be some kind of “focus” for this endlessly repeating battle.

But suddenly, Lawrence snapped out of his daze.

He leaped out from his hiding spot. Under the sailors' startled cries and wide-eyed gazes, the old captain sprinted like the wind toward the spot where that last man had fallen.

The hall, which had fallen silent, was startled by his sudden intrusion. The monsters that had not yet faded reacted almost at once. Chaotic roars and the thunder of gunfire erupted again!

Shouts from the sailors came from behind: "Cover the captain!"

But Lawrence seemed unable to hear them. He just lowered his head and charged forward. It felt as if several bullets hit him, but to him that no longer mattered. He dashed across half the hall, jumped into the trench, and threw himself at the last explosive charge, reaching out toward it—

Then his fingers passed straight through the crate of explosives.

Lawrence fell awkwardly into the trench and stared blankly at the sight before him.

Just like the Queenguard Corps around him, that crate of explosives was also only a phantom to him.

The explosive charge that had failed to detonate fifty years ago could not be triggered today by someone who came after.

Bullets whistled in and slammed into the ground nearby. Roars drew closer. Some sludge monsters had already rushed into the trench, ready to tear him to pieces.

But Lawrence still stared at the crate of explosives, feeling only a vast sense of absurdity and mockery.

Yet at that moment, something suddenly moved at the edge of his vision.

The old captain looked up in shock and saw that it was the young man who had just fallen who was moving.

The young man with the heavy wrench at his waist trembled and slowly lifted his head. His eyes fixed on the figure before him—a man dressed like a captain, wrapped in strange green flames.

Lawrence froze for a moment, then suddenly realized: “You can see me?!”

But the young man seemed not to hear the question. His lips moved, as if he were quickly repeating some words. He repeated them several times before Lawrence barely caught what he was saying—

“…I’ve seen it. Right, I’ve seen this flame… I’ve seen it…”

“Seen it? Flame? What are you talking about?”

Lawrence stared with wide eyes and could not help asking.

But the young man did not answer. He only kept repeating the same words over and over. And while he muttered, he slowly pushed himself up. Covered in blood, he still managed to climb to his feet, bit by bit!

Under Lawrence’s disbelieving gaze, the blood-soaked young man picked up the last explosive charge again. With a muffled groan, he climbed up the embankment wall beside the slope and staggered toward the thorned door, still muttering something under his breath.

Lawrence heard what he was muttering, but could not understand it. It sounded like a string of names—

“Nemo… General Tyrian… Crow…”

That blood-soaked figure stumbled on, mumbling.

But he barely made it a few steps.

As soon as he reached level ground, gunshots rang out from the other side, and the bloodied figure fell.

But almost in the same instant he fell, a bent old figure suddenly rose from the spot where he had fallen.

Lawrence watched in disbelief. He saw exactly where the old man appeared —from the pool of blood.

He was the reflection in the blood at the moment the young man died.

“Ah, I finally made it…”

The hunched old man bent down and picked up the last crate of explosives. A smile then bloomed on his face, so bright and impossible to understand.

“I made it!”

He shouted, and he laughed out loud. Hugging the crate of explosives, he cheerfully lit the fuse and then almost gleefully ran straight toward the thorned door with it in his arms.

“I made it!

“Engineer Wilson reporting in!

“Engineer Wilson requests to return to the unit!

“I made it!”

Boom!!!

The earth-shaking explosion rocked the entire hall and every corridor connected to it.

Chapter 427: sacrificial rite

Ssshrip—

A vicious spike pierced through flesh, carving yet another meaningless wound into a body already covered in injuries. The whispers and howls at her ears suddenly grew excited. Those blasphemous creations seemed to crow with pride at the blow, letting out sickening noise.

Agatha raised her hand and struck back with her Gatekeeper's cane, knocking away the Annihilator whose body bristled with bone spurs and had almost lost all human shape. A sharp, cracking sound rang beside her ear.

The sound stunned her for less than a second before she realized it was her own battle Gatekeeper's cane breaking.

The weapon that had been with her for many years had snapped. Facing enemies that seemed without end, it had lasted to the very last step.

"You have already done very well, Miss Gatekeeper," that disgusting, affected voice sounded again. "For a sacrificial victim, a bit of warm-up does help the effect of the sacrificial rite. But too much exercise is not good."

Agatha held the broken Gatekeeper's cane and slowly raised her head. Dried blood let her open only one eye. Through a narrow, red-tinged view, she finally saw the scene in the hall clearly.

The eerie shadowy overlay had faded. What now appeared before her was the center of the sewer, already turned completely into a place of sacrifice. On every wall and corridor around her, foul, blasphemous symbols and marks of corruption covered the stone. Things like stone stalagmites or dried branches spread across the ceiling above. On the floor of the hall in front of her lay a huge “pool”—

It had once been solid floor, now corroded into a vast pit. The pit was filled with thick, pitch-black sludge, slowly heaving and making wave after wave of nauseating, squelching sounds.

Countless Annihilators ringed the hall. They and the Abyssal demons that lived with them were like swarms of insects gathered around a stinking cauldron. They whispered blessings and let out crazed growls toward the pool of pitch-black sludge at the center of the hall. Under that noisy prayer, the sludge grew fuller and more active.

This was the site of a sacrificial rite. They were waiting for the final sacrificial victim. And in the eyes of these fanatics, that sacrificial victim was the Gatekeeper of the city-state of Frostholm.

Before this, they had even copied another Gatekeeper. Now that Gatekeeper too was reaching some sacrificial rite site.

“Actions you believe to be free will are in fact just steps toward a stage set long in advance. Don’t you find this arrangement rather… beautiful?”

In the center of the pool of black sludge, a young man with short blond hair spread his arms toward Agatha. His face was still handsome, but his entire lower body had already become a swollen, writhing mass. Now he was clearly some sort of “tip of a tentacle” that the sludge had stretched out and reshaped, mimicking human form in a nauseating way.

“All right, the time is almost here, and you have already adapted to this place. Now step forward. It is time for the sacrificial rite.”

At the edge of the sludge pool, a limb like a tentacle slowly rose. It grew out of the mud, and its tip slowly turned into a hard, dagger-like point.

That life-taking tentacle of the sacrificial rite slowly moved toward Agatha.

But Agatha only watched it quietly, then suddenly murmured: “More or less… this spot…”

She slowly reached toward her chest.

But in the next second, her movement suddenly stopped.

In that instant, she lost control of her own body.

“I know you want to do something—something not in our plan.”

In senses that had suddenly gone dull, she heard the blond young man’s voice coming from the other side. She tried with all her strength to raise her head, but could only see a bit of his figure at the edge of her vision.

“But sadly for you, to prevent the sacrificial victim from entering a runaway state, we prepared ‘safety measures’ from the very start. Did you never notice? All the way here, you wiped out so many replicas. You even destroyed more than ten of my avatar forms. All of that was only to bind you bit by bit to this city of mirror world.

“You felt you could sense the location of this sanctuary more and more clearly? You felt you could ‘smell’ us heretics more and more clearly? Did you ever wonder why that was changing?

“It is very simple. Before you reached this place, you were already one of us, my lady.”

Agatha finally raised her head. Before her, the sharp spike was slowly nearing her heart. Her body still could not move.

Now she finally understood the sense of wrongness she had felt on the way here. She understood why these cultists had wasted so many cannon-fodder lackeys on “war of attrition” tactics against her.

Everything had only been for slow, subtle corruption.

In the next second, the sharp spike went straight into her heart without any pause.

In the mud pool, the blond cultist suddenly raised his hands. The instant the Gatekeeper’s heart was pierced, he cried out in ecstatic prayer: “The sacrificial victim has been offered! The Saint’s life will be the first step in our lord’s kingdom descending! Call out the holy master’s name and welcome the promised day!”

In an instant, all the cultists in the hall shouted. Those misshapen figures who had symbiotic pacts with demons sank into frenzy, crying out the name of the Abyssal Deep lord in their madness. Some swung their own daggers and slashed open their flesh, pouring their blood into the black sludge surging in the center of the hall. Even the demons beside them fell into a fever, howling in all kinds of wild, broken voices!

Yet amid all the mad, twisted howling, the black matter in the sludge pool only churned violently for a few seconds before slowly growing calm again.

Standing in the center of the “pool”, the blond cultist finally sensed that something was wrong. He jerked out of his joy and stared in shock at the pool growing calm again. Then his gaze went to the spike that had pierced the Saint’s heart and to the Gatekeeper standing at the edge of the sacrificial rite grounds.

The Gatekeeper, covered in wounds and pale-faced.

“…You have no life?!” The madman finally lost his arrogance and poise. He pointed at Agatha in utter shock. “You… why are you a corpse?!”

Agatha looked at him calmly. At last, a small smile appeared at the corner of her mouth.

“Even though I hadn’t figured out your final goal before, how could I, as the Gatekeeper, fail to notice something was wrong with my own body…”

As she spoke, she slowly raised her arm. Now that the sacrificial rite had failed, she felt this body slowly coming back under her control.

“When I realized you wanted to lure me to the gathering place, realized this was likely some kind of sacrificial rite that demanded life, I did one thing…”

She slowly grasped the spike piercing her heart. Her fingers tightened bit by bit, and thin threads of emerald flame flowed between them, seeping into the spike.

She lifted her eyes and fixed her gaze on the cultist in the sludge pool.

“Every heretic sacrificial rite is based on fresh blood—I drained my own blood.”

“You… do you know what you’ve done?!” The madman’s eyes bulged with rage, his finger shaking as he pointed at Agatha. “You… you…”

“It doesn’t matter. It’s a small thing,” Agatha only smiled and shook her head. More and more flame leaked from her fingers. “As long as I can send the Fire Seed where it needs to go…”

“You said wh—”

The cultist in the sludge pool spoke without thinking, but before he could finish, another deafening boom suddenly came from the far side of the

gathering hall. The earthshaking blast shattered the last strands holding this sacrificial rite together.

A large door deep in the hall, along with a wide stretch of wall beside it, was blown away by a load of high explosive!

Boom!!

Stone and concrete shattered and flew. Fragments of the door and countless bits of strange black matter mixed within swept into the hall like shrapnel. Several cultists closest to the door were blown away on the spot, and the rest cried out in shock—

“They broke through the door!”

“Impossible! They couldn’t break through for decades… How could a bunch of phantoms break their own loop?!”

In the center of the sludge pool, the blond cultist leader turned in shock toward the blast. But before he could see clearly the shapes charging in from beyond the thorned door, a pillar of green fire surged up at the edge of his sight.

He turned his gaze and saw that the sacrificial victim who should have been offered to the Abyssal Deep lord was now wrapped in flames, burning fiercely in a terrifying spirit form blaze!

The moment the door at the far end of the hall was blown open, Agatha finally broke fully free of the sacrificial rite’s control. In that brief instant, she ignited the Fire Seed.

The fuel was herself.

spirit flame surged up!

In a view suddenly filled with eerie green fire, Agatha saw that the wall opposite the “pool” had collapsed into a large hole. A group of people who

looked like sailors, their bodies burning with the same green flames as hers, charged into the hall.

The flames on them resonated strongly with the Fire Seed burning on her.

Agatha smiled.

Knowledge flowed into her mind. She understood.

In the flames, she slowly spread her arms and lifted them as if in welcome.

“The fire is lit.”

Chapter 428: Burning a God

Light flowed through the thicket of thorns. The thoughts of the Elder Gods spread in the darkness. A broken body squeezed through the narrow gaps between the thorns. A shaking will crossed the abyss of madness and foolishness.

[How long had she been moving through this space full of chaos? How much corruption from the Elder Gods had she already touched? Was she still a whole person now, or only a shard drifting in the chaos, about to be taken in and absorbed by it?]

Agatha could no longer tell. She could not tell anything apart. She could not even tell where her body ended and the mass of chaos around her began. In her sight, her body looked like a blot of ink slowly spreading in water. The edges of her body were blurry, like liquid soaking into paper. It felt as if she was not walking through this darkness, but flowing forward inside a thick, sticky fluid that had the same nature as her own body.

She knew that everything was almost at its limit. elements. She did not know whether this thing had really created all things in the world. But one point was clear: it had created the body she had now.

Ice melted into water. Mist turned into wind. A replica that had condensed out of elements would return to the “sea” made of elements. The so-called “personal will” inside this body would soon turn into a small, unimportant point of light in that chaotic sea, food for the tiny glimmers that kept moving through the thicket of thorns.

She was only a replica. She was only a shadow. She carried memories of twenty-four years of life. In those memories were her home, her comrades, and everything she loved or hated. But out of those twenty-four years, what truly belonged to her might be only three days, or even less.

For some reason, Governor Winston's voice suddenly seemed to echo in her mind, full of sighs and regret:

"There was no meaning in any of it…"

A living man who had a real life had summed up his own years like this in the endless dark. A replica who had only three days of life was now walking through the darkness, trying to face the Elder Gods head-on.

"So stupid…"

Agatha sighed softly as she spoke. Her voice melted into the darkness and turned into faint ripples. In her mind, endless streams of information kept rising and falling. A mysterious will made of "0" and "1" washed over her thoughts.

She knew she was about to melt into that vast will. Even though this place only stored one flash of thought from the Elder Gods at a single moment in time, its huge size was still far beyond what her weak mind could bear.

But it was fine. She had already arrived.

She had walked through the huge forest of thorns and reached the deepest part of the darkness.

That "tentacle" like a pillar holding up the sky stood quietly before her. The surface of the great pillar was full of strange dark blue lines. Against the dim, chaotic background, it looked like some kind of monument that recorded ancient Truth.

Agatha slowly raised her head, then reached out a hand and tried to touch it.

Black fragments and smoke drifted up in her sight.

The thorns had already cut countless wounds across her skin. A substance like black sludge now poured from inside her like fog. It spread out and melted into the space around her. The rising black fragments and smoke were things drifting out of her own body.

Agatha felt that she must now look like a horrible doll covered in cracks. Even if someone wrapped her whole body in bandages, it would not hide this terrifying shape.

At the same time, the “tentacle” of the Elder Gods did not respond to her touch.

It did not show any mighty power. It did not show any frightening side. It did not even react to the outside world at all. Her fingertips only felt a touch that was a little cold and soft, with a bit of roughness in it.

[Is it because this is only a vision projected here from the Deep Sea? Or because my existence is too small, so small that I cannot even draw the Elder Gods’ notice?]

Agatha frowned. She tried to think about whether there was anything she could still do in these last moments. But after thinking for a long time, she found that there seemed to be nothing left she could do.

She had reached the end. She had learned the truth of this darkness. She had walked through the thicket of thorns that stood for the Elder Gods’ thoughts. At the very end of this darkness, she had seen part of the Abyssal Lord’s true form. She had even touched this tentacle of the Elder Gods with her own hands.

There was no more truth left for her to dig out, and no more mission waiting for her to carry out. This last stretch of road was, in truth, less for

the duty of a Gatekeeper and more to satisfy one bit of her own stubborn will.

Now, it was time to rest.

So Agatha let out a light breath and relaxed her body. She slowly turned around and leaned against the huge tentacle beside her, as if leaning against a pillar.

A strange thought suddenly came up in Agatha's mind. She leaned there in the dark and muttered to herself: "I probably don't even have a soul that can set off on the road…" But soon she gave a self-mocking smile and shook her head: "Of course not. If I had a soul, I would have given that other 'Gatekeeper' a lot of trouble when I went through that door… And after I went over, what about her? A person can't walk through that door twice…"

She went on in a low voice: "I wonder how things are at the Cathedral… Did that group who went down the shaft make it back… But it seems they don't really need to worry…"

She kept talking to herself in the dark like this, as if she could not control the drifting of her thoughts. Whatever she thought in her heart, she let it slip out in words.

But just then, a strange burning heat suddenly cut off her mumbling.

Agatha jolted out of her dazed fog.

In that instant, she felt flames baking her whole self. The terrible heat seemed ready to burn through her soul at once. She felt her mind boil in the fire. The thoughts that had almost been fully taken over by this place also cleared up. She struggled to stand in this vision of fire burning her body. She did not know what had happened, but in the next second, a voice drilled into her mind—

"The fire is lit."

It was her own voice.

In the dark, Agatha opened her eyes wide. It was as if she saw a vision. She saw herself standing before a deep pool full of rolling black sludge. The rim of the pool was ringed with disgusting cultists and demons. The mud in the pool churned and spread malice. She stood before that mire, raised both hands high, and they blazed up like the Sacred beacon Torch.

A faint green suddenly rose in her sight, as if the vision had pierced the line between real and unreal.

Agatha looked down. On the surface of her arm, which had already started to break apart and drift away, flames were rising. The ghost-green flame was exactly the same as the one she had seen in the vision.

In the passage that this flame built, she suddenly felt it—she felt another mind, another self.

The other self also felt her.

She understood what she should do now. She still had something to do.

Agatha suddenly turned around and stared at the tentacle that rose like a pillar to the sky. The brightest smile she had worn since she entered this darkness bloomed on her face. A clear light showed in her eyes again.

She took a step forward and reached out both hands toward the tentacle. Flames quickly swallowed her whole body. Yet the pain of being burned now felt like a great reward. Agatha spread her arms wide. It was the same pose she had seen herself take before the deep pool in that vision.

Like an embrace, the Gatekeeper threw herself at the tentacle.

One great power would clash with another. Those mad cultists wanted to use the Gatekeeper to build a bridge for the sacrificial victim. But this roaring fire would cut that bridge off for good.

Boom!

A terrible roar rang out in the dark. Almost in the blink of an eye, the flames swept across this twisted, chaotic space. In the spirit form fire that rolled and rose like a storm, the huge tentacle turned into a burning Sacred beacon Torch and shook hard in the fire.

Agatha felt her flesh and blood quickly melt in the flames. Her body, which had been made of corruption from the start, now became one part of this complete purification by fire. Yet she did not feel any fear. Instead, she struggled to lift her head and looked back in the direction she had come from.

The “thicket of thorns” was also burning. Under the wildly spreading spirit flame, it looked like a strange and grand crown of trees.

“Goodbye… Governor Winston…”

Agatha whispered to herself and hugged the tentacle even tighter in the fire, quietly waiting for the end of her fate.

But just before her mind faded away, she suddenly felt something.

The flames burned through her and burned through the tentacle as well. In the bridge that the spirit form fire built, she felt for the first time this “limb of the Elder Gods” respond to her.

She lifted her head in shock and looked at the patterned surface of the tentacle. She watched the fire run inside and outside it. She felt the stream of information that poured into her mind from the spirit flame. She saw what looked like countless eyes opening at once all over the surface of the tentacle. Every eye was madly sending knowledge and information into her.

In the end, all the knowledge and information turned into a storm inside her head—

11101001…11100101 10001000…10010011…

The long strings of “0”s and “1”s filled the last bits of thought Agatha had left.

But this time, she understood what they meant.

“Error… replicant…”

Shocked, she sounded out the message that this limb of the Elder Gods sent to her. She understood its will and at last pieced together the answer.

She stared at the tentacle she had set on fire.

“This is also… a replica?!”

In the next second, the blazing green flame swallowed the last trace of her mind.

Chapter 429: The ritual in the Chaos of Battle

The ritual had been broken.

That Queen's Guard Corps had already been cycling in a loop for half a century. When, for some unknown reason, they suddenly broke out of that loop; when intruders blew up the "Gate of Ascension" in the ritual hall; when a group of people from who knew where rushed into the hall—when the sacrificial victim they had chosen, right in front of the pool of elements, instead gave her own sacrificial rite to the green flames. At that moment, this lofty and final ritual had already reached a point beyond repair.

Now, enemy cultists had rushed in. The destroyers were madly slaughtering the Holy Lord's followers and tearing apart the hard work of these long decades.

"What have you done?!"

In the center of the deep pool, the cultist leader who looked like a blond young man let out a furious roar. His body shot up to a great height. Held up by black sludge, he turned into a swollen and horrible giant. He swung an arm toward Agatha. Countless thorns and bone spurs shot up from the pool, grew at a wild speed, and rushed like a flood toward the Gatekeeper who still stood in the flames.

Yet none of the attacks even reached Agatha's body. They turned at once into ash under the burning of the ghost-green flame. That strange fire instead crawled back along the trail of the ash, slowly burning away the

sacrificial rite symbols and filthy offerings around the Sludge Pool, and then spread toward the pool itself.

Agatha was still wrapped in fire. The roaring spirit form fire had already begun to gush out from inside her. Every wound on her body had turned into a path for the flames to pour out. From a distance, it looked as if the fire had become liquid and was now flowing in her veins. At some point, the awful pain of being burned had faded away. She laughed in the fire, lifted her head, and stared freely at that furious yet helpless heretic with a gaze. She whispered, as if to herself: “Ah… I understand now…”

In the next second, the spirit flame burned away her eyeballs in an instant. Fire spewed out from the empty sockets. With these burned-out “eyes”, she looked around her, at the cultists around the deep pool who had fallen into great chaos.

Wherever her gaze passed, every cultist began to burn. The demons bound to them by symbiotic pacts also began to burn. Every unholy item in the hall turned into fuel for the Fire Seeds. Even the hall itself slowly took on the feel of flame soaking through it.

The Flame Usurper had granted her divine authority. With the divine authority of fire, she would end the blasphemy here. This was the Truth she had seen in the moment when her own eyes burned away.

The cultist in the center of the mud was not worth worrying about. He was only a freak who had finished his own sacrificial rite and transformation. What really kept this place running were the ugly, twisted heretics raving and howling around the Sludge Pool.

“Stop! Stop at once! You have no idea what you’re doing! A ritual in a runaway state is bad for everyone! It has already reached—”

The cultist leader, who had turned into a swollen giant, shouted in vain. He kept raising barriers, trying to hold back the flames that were spreading through the hall. But just then, a gunshot suddenly came from the side and cut off his shout.

“Bang!”

A young warrior in a soldier’s uniform from half a century ago rushed in, an old rifle in his hands. He raised the gun and fired at the swollen, twisted giant in the center of the deep pool.

The brave warrior was swallowed in the next moment by rushing black sludge. But more soldiers were charging into the hall behind him.

By the time line, they had already passed the cycle node of the Queen’s Guard Corps’ “counterattack battle”. All these phantom warriors should have faded away. But it was clear that this loop had already changed because the gate of thorns had been destroyed. The Queen’s Guard Corps, who should have vanished at the next full hour, had returned from the cycle to this place and now began to attack this final hall.

The landing squad led by Captain Lawrence was also locked in battle with the nearby cultists and Abyssal demons. They had used up all their bullets, but they still had sharp sabers and long swords, and for a time they had bodies that did not fear death. So even when they faced dark priests and demonic creatures who wielded all kinds of dangerous powers, they fought like mighty supernatural and did not fall behind.

With a loud clang, Captain Lawrence cut down a bone spike flying toward him with his short sword. He then dodged to the side, barely avoiding a fireball that almost exploded on him. He stepped forward through the flames and sliced through the chain on the back of a cultist’s neck. The dark priest’s body turned at once into drifting ash. Then he lifted his head and

looked toward the long-haired woman standing before the Sludge Pool, her whole body burning like a Sacred beacon Torch.

The old captain shouted: “Young lady! We’ve come to help! We all work for ‘the captain’, right—what ship are you from?”

He could see it very clearly. The young woman standing in the flames burned with the same ghost-green fire as he did, so she was clearly on their side. At the same time, the fire on that young lady burned deeper in color and higher than the one on his own body. That kind of “ally” was clearly not an ordinary one. The flames on her were bigger and greener—so she had to be a big shot under Captain Duncan.

Using his rich experience as both an adventurer and a captain, Captain Lawrence made a simple, plain judgment. His conclusion was that he should take the lead and greet this future high-ranking coworker.

Agatha stared in shock at the tough old man dressed like a captain who was shouting at her from across the chaos.

After two or three seconds, Agatha could not hold back anymore and shouted: “What did you say?! It’s too loud in here! I can’t hear you!”

Lawrence paused, then turned to the subordinate next to him to make sure: “She answered me, right?”

“How should I know!” Anomaly 077 was closest. The mummified corpse was yelling at the top of his lungs, his voice full of panic and fear. He jumped around between the flames spreading from all sides, trying his best to dodge the flying bullets, fireballs, bone spikes, and even blasted-off arms and legs. Chips already showed on the blades of the twin knives in his hands. “I’m a sailor! Why am I fighting cultists to the death in a sewer right now? This is the work of a landing squad member!”

“You didn’t say that when we came ashore,” Lawrence shouted. “You were as excited as a pirate getting ready to raid a city-state.”

“You were the one who said we aren’t pirates!”

“Then I now appoint you a landing squad member.”

“You fu—”

“Hm?”

“You fu—sir…”

Agatha listened blankly to the wild shouting between those rough, tough sailors and their captain. She watched the scene of pure chaos in front of her.

[Who are these people? Where did they come from? What are they even doing?]

She saw the strangers burning with the same green flames as she was, and the cultists in the hall locked in fierce battle with them. She saw a whole group of soldiers, like ghosts from an ancient age, rush in and start firing in all directions. From time to time, some of the soldiers called out the name of the Queen of Frostholm. Everything here had gone beyond what she could understand. It was as if…

It was as if, after she chose to carry out her own sacrificial rite, the whole world’s style had changed.

But soon a rushing sound of wind in her ears cut off her wild thoughts.

The swollen, twisted giant bent down toward her.

It roared: “Everything… can no longer be stopped…”

Filthy black sludge in a runaway state spewed from all over its body. The handsome face of the blond young man it once had was gone without a

trace. In its place now was a horrible monster with only a rough human shape.

Half its body was covered in crisscrossing mouths. The scraping and whispering of sharp teeth made one's skin crawl. Its head slowly split open in front of Agatha. The crack was packed with eyes full of malice. elements had fully corrupted the human body this monster once had and taken its place. It had become one part of that pool of mud, and even… part of some bigger, more twisted will.

The swollen giant stared hard at Agatha with its countless eyes. The mud spreading around it had already caught fire. The flames even crawled back along the mud and burned on its body. Yet the monster seemed to feel no pain at all. It only repeated again and again: "Cannot stop… cannot stop… error, error…"

Agatha lifted her head and met the monster's gaze. The flames pouring from her eye sockets twisted the air around her. She said: "You have already failed. You should be able to feel it. The so-called 'passage' has been cut off. The Inversion between mirror world and the Mortal Realm has stopped."

"Stopped?" For a brief moment, the monster seemed to wake at her last words. In its countless twisted eyes, a human hatred showed again. It snarled: "Fool… You think that just because you sacrificed yourself… we have no other sacrificial victims?!"

Agatha froze.

In the next second, she saw the giant suddenly raise both arms high. Those arms changed at once. Like dried, cracked branches, they grew and split in a rush, turning into huge masses of thorn-like structures. They stabbed into the roof of the hall and into every nearby pipe. Between the sharp tips of the thorns, faint lights began to race by, like fireflies.

From deep inside this “thorn forest”, a cry full of mad joy rang out:

“I see it! I grasp it! I understand it!
“What a mighty creation! What a grand Blueprint! O greatest and holiest Lord… I have grasped Your will. I have grasped it… To remake this world, yes, remake it… All of us, and all things in this world, will be born again from the flesh of God—believers, the time of sacrifice has come!”

“The time of sacrifice has come!”

Under the stunned gaze of Agatha and of the landing squad led by Lawrence, all the remaining Annihilators in the hall began to cheer in wild joy. It was as if they had truly received some revelation from the Truth. In that roaring wave of shouts, they threw themselves one after another into the pool of mud in the center of the hall!

(I have a bold idea!)

Chapter 430:

The mad took madness as their final road – the Annihilation Heretics who followed the Abyssal Lord embraced their deaths in the most chilling way.

In the wake of the ritual being completely destroyed, the Annihilators who survived at the scene chose a collective sacrificial rite to forcefully complete the Inversion of the city of mirror world.

Even with all of Lawrence’s experience from spending half his life at sea, he had never seen a sight so terrifying, so insane –

Hundreds of Annihilators threw themselves in ecstasy toward that churning pool of sludge. They melted and broke apart in the mud, yet were wild with joy. The Abyssal demons that had a symbiotic pact with them roared as they snapped their chains and self-detonated around the “pool”. The filthy smoke and corrupt breath even blocked the advance of the Queen’s Guard Corps. A huge crown of thorns rose from the center of the sludge pool. As the cultists carried out their mad sacrificial rite, it grew fast and in the blink of an eye covered the whole hall.

“I have understood!”

A crazed roar came from within that crown of thorns, as if a thousand voices were stacked inside it.

“We have understood!”

Countless cultists who had thrown themselves into the sludge shouted as well, their voices shaking the Second Waterway.

“I will carry it out!” “We will carry it out!”

“Fulfill the Creator’s Blueprint!” “Fulfill the Creator’s Blueprint!”

Boom!

A blazing fire rose and spread through the hall, almost at once swallowing that crown of thorns. Lawrence only had time to look up before he saw the crown breaking apart and collapsing in ghostly flames, turning into drifting gray-black dust that fell down. The pool of black sludge in the center of the hall also caught fire. As the spirit flame rose, the churning of the mud quickly slowed and soon turned into dry, burnt earth.

The last group of cultists who had flung themselves toward the sludge pool turned straight into ash in that fire.

Yet the shaking of the Second Waterway did not stop. The howling that echoed in the sewers still circled around. The crazed shouts of the cultists during their sacrificial rite now echoed through this underground space like ghosts, sending chills down one’s spine.

Lawrence lifted his head in shock and confusion and looked around. He still did not quite understand what had happened, and spoke without thinking: “Did we make it in time? The ritual did not finish, right…”

“It looks like all the cultists are dead… and that ‘tree’ burned up too…” Anomaly 077 spoke in a nervous voice, eyeing this place uneasily. “But why do I feel like…”

“Not yet.”

A voice mixed with the crackle of flames suddenly came from not far away, cutting off the exchange between Lawrence and the “sailor”.

Lawrence looked up at once toward that side.

Agatha also turned her gaze toward this group of “strangers” who had come to help.

She still stood there, still in the pose of someone burning in flames. Compared with when she had first entered this city of mirror world, she had become something completely different –

Her black clothes had turned into a ragged outer robe that hung on her like the tattered cloth of a poor monk. Her body looked like a broken doll, with shocking wounds and even cracks everywhere. Her blood had long since drained away. Now, only green flame flowed like water from those wounds. Her eyes had been burned out by the fire of the Flame Usurper, leaving only empty hollows.

Yet in those empty sockets, two of the brightest flames danced. She had lost the eyes of her flesh, but gained another kind of sight beyond imagination.

She could see that the energy in the hall still flowed. She could even see the energy of the whole city of mirror world flowing. She saw an enormous structure running through the entire city, still lifting it upward, making the city keep “rising” toward the world of the Mortal Realm.

Agatha took a step forward. The spirit form flames spread under her feet, making the floor sizzle. She reached out, grabbed a thorn vine that stretched out from the sludge pool, and squeezed gently.

That piece of “thorn” had already been dried by the spirit form flames. She crushed it into pieces with ease. Yet among the falling fragments, tiny motes of light still flowed.

“mirror world is still rising…” She sounded as if she was talking to herself, yet also as if she was reporting to someone. “The heretics here are all wiped out, but what they left is still running… This city of mirror world is alive. It

is moving toward the Mortal Realm on its own… I am sorry, I do not know how to stop it."

Lawrence walked over, looking at Agatha in curiosity: "Who are you talking to…"

As he spoke, a violent shaking and a roar from above cut him off. He and the sailors looked up in panic, and a sight they would never forget filled everyone's eyes –

The hall shook hard, and the rock, concrete, steel, and earth above it, no one knew how thick, suddenly turned transparent. Through that suddenly transparent ground, he clearly saw layer after layer of structures above their heads!

Drainage tunnels, power pipes, steam delivery systems, the subway, and above that the mountain, the streets, the buildings, the Cathedral… the entire city-state of Frostholm!

He saw Frostholm. Across the thick layers of ground, he saw Frostholm in the world of the Mortal Realm. He saw the city wrapped in heavy fog. Countless monsters still attacked everything inside the city from within the mist. The city-state's Guard Corps and the Guardian units fought the monsters in despair. Darkness spread through the city. Fear brewed in every corner…

Blood, smoke, death.

"Oh… I think we are in big trouble…" Anomaly 077 also raised his head like everyone else and muttered after a long time, "Or maybe the people above our heads are the ones in big trouble…"

Lawrence shuddered awake and realized what was about to happen. Even though the cultists were all dead, their final sacrificial rite, their ritual, had still worked. This city of mirror world had gained the trait of independent

existence and was still rising according to some “Blueprint” design. If this continued, Frostholm in the Mortal Realm would never survive!

“It cannot be stopped?!” He stared, eyes wide, and turned to Agatha, shouting, “We are about to overlap with the world of the Mortal Realm!”

But Agatha only turned her head in silence, her gaze full of flame falling on Lawrence.

She did not speak, but a calm and solemn voice sounded directly in Lawrence’s mind: “Do not rush. This is only one part of solving the problem.”

Lawrence froze for a moment, then realized where the voice in his head came from. The muscles all over his body visibly tensed. “C-captain!”

“Relax a little. And – stand steady in a moment.”

Lawrence stared blankly, eyes wide.

At the same time, on the side of the Mortal Realm.

The roar of cannon fire still echoed over the vast endless sea. The remaining City Navy of Frostholm and the Sea Mist fleet still fought hard to hold back the “ghost” ships that kept rising from the dense fog.

As time passed, the number of ghost ships coming out of the fog did not drop. Instead, it kept growing.

“Unknown vessel sighted off the port side! It is a fast gunboat… close-in guns, prepare to fire!”

“A Frostholm Navy frigate has sunk in nearby waters, hull number S-30, strike it from the identification list!”

“Fire on the aft deck! Damage control, damage control!”

Shouts passing orders, the roar of the main guns firing, explosions, the heavy crash of water columns slamming into hulls, all the sounds mixed together and brewed an almost Doomsday-like air.

Tyrian stood on the bridge of the Sea Mist, both hands on the rail in front of him, his single eye fixed on the distant sea, his face dark as if it held a brewing storm.

The battle had gone on for a very long time, yet there was still no hope of victory. Enemy ships like ghosts still poured out from the thick fog around the city-state, and the blockade over the whole sea area had not been broken.

Undying sailors did not feel tired, but this long, intense fight still kept draining the strength of the Sea Mist fleet. The Sea Mist's own repair ability was close to its limit. It could no longer even put out the great fires on its deck and could only rely on damage control teams rushing back and forth. The ship Crow had just pulled out of the battle a dozen minutes ago and was now dragging its broken hull back toward Frostholm's main island.

If even the Sea Mist fleet was in this state, there was no need to think about the Frostholm Navy made of humans.

From the reports over the radio alone, one could tell that the Frostholm Navy was in bad shape. Their exhaustion had reached the limit, and the damage and losses on each warship were close to a critical point.

The ironic part was that for the past half century, almost everyone in the Sea Mist fleet had mocked and cursed that navy almost every day. Yet now, almost every member of the Sea Mist fleet hoped those humans could hold on a bit longer, and that a few more of them could live.

A thunderous boom came from far away, and a huge flash of light appeared in the dense fog. Right after, that huge flash turned into a string of

continuous fire bursts and explosions.

Tyrian looked in that direction on instinct and at once ordered the signalman to find out what those explosions were. After a bout of chaos, First Mate Aiden brought bad news.

“The Frostholm Navy main battleship Lord Blücher has had its steam core badly damaged. The reactor boiler has exploded. She is sinking.”

Tyrian did not speak. He only slowly closed his eye.

The Lord Blücher… the Sea Mist had dealt with her a few times in the past two years. The ship’s commander was a very traditional Frostholm man.

He was a good man. It was a good ship.

But now, farewell forever.

“Write it down. Maybe in the future, we will have a chance to mourn,” Tyrian opened his eye and slowly shook his head. “Right now we do not have…”

As he spoke, the scene outside the porthole suddenly changed and cut him off.

He looked out the window in surprise. The first mate and many others on the bridge also looked out on instinct.

The fog over the sea… was thinning.

Chapter 431:

The fog was thinning.

Since the battle began, this was the first time the heavy fog over the Frostholm waters had shown signs of fading. Around the Sea Mist, in the direction of Frostholm, from the sea surface to the sky, all the thick mist was shrinking at a speed visible to the naked eye. The dim gloom that covered everything retreated, and the whole sea area slowly became clear.

And on the sea where the fog faded, one could see burning ships everywhere, the replica fleet with its twisted and frightening shapes, and countless floating wreckage and patches of burning oil.

Thick smoke rolled and spread over the sea where the mist retreated.

First Mate Aiden was the first to run to the window. He stared, eyes wide, at the sea outside where the fog was fading. After a long moment he shouted, “The fog is retreating! Captain! The fog is retreating!”

“I can see it,” Tyrian also walked quickly to the window. Yet the grave look in his one eye did not fade at all just because the fog did. “It is retreating… really retreating?”

“Captain, is this not a good thing?” Aiden at once noticed the wrong note in Tyrian’s tone and turned his head in confusion. “The fog is gone. That means the Anomaly power crouching over Frostholm also…”

“No. Something is wrong.” Tyrian cut the first mate off with a serious look. He stared hard at the distant sea, his gaze growing even sharper. “The fog is

gone, but those ghost ships are still there, and the look of the sea…”

“The sea?” Aiden frowned in confusion and turned to look into the distance. A second later, he finally drew in a sharp breath.

Just as the captain said, something was wrong. The replica fleet on all sides did not show any sign of fading. There were even new ghost ships rising from the sea. And in this process, the whole sea area was slowly growing darker!

Large patches of pitch-black were spreading through the water. In the darkness, something was growing. Countless vague shapes were drawing closer to the surface. This scene… was as if something very huge, or some enormous group, was surfacing from the Deep Sea!

“What the…”

Aiden muttered without thinking, but before he could finish, a string of huge booms suddenly shattered the very short calm that had followed the fading of the mist.

The sea nearby split open and countless huge ships floated up. Some looked like wrecks, some twisted like monsters, and some carried a strange, half-familiar look. In the suddenly black sea, it was as if the entire replica fleet had surged out all at once!

“Attention! Enemy ships appearing! Enemy ships… they are everywhere!”

A seaman shouted in terror. The close-in guns along the edge of the deck roared at the same time. The thunder of gunfire rang over the sea almost at once. Shells howled through the air, and huge water columns and balls of fire from the explosions once again covered the sea.

But in this sudden chaos, Tyrian still used his gaze on the sea, watching those enemies that rose one after another from the water.

He recognized some of them – and so did his soldiers.

“It is the Knight! The Knight we sank at the very start!”

“The Black Flag soldier! The Black Flag soldier that sank fifteen minutes ago! It has appeared again!”

“The Courage! And the Prince Jotun!”

“Captain!” First Mate Aiden’s voice reached Tyrian’s ears, carrying a panic he had never shown before. “The whole replica fleet… the ones we destroyed… they have all appeared again!”

Tyrian opened his mouth, about to speak, when a voice suddenly rose in his mind: “… This is normal, because the root of mirror world is still there.”

“Father?!” Tyrian jerked in shock and instinctively looked around for something that could form a mirror. “You are now…?”

“Do not rush, Tyrian. The timing is just right.”

Tyrian quickly calmed down. He motioned for Aiden to take command of the fight and answered fast in his mind: “What do you need me to do?”

…

At the same time that the fog over the sea was fading, the heavy mist covering the city-state of Frostholm also retreated. But just like at sea, the fading of the fog did not mean the end of the crisis.

mirror world was still rising. Another, far more terrifying Frostholm city-state was slowly overlapping with the Mortal Realm.

The city-state’s Guard Corps, still holding out, had built street barricades to block countless monsters that seemed to appear from nowhere. The roar of guns shook the city. The peace and safety of the past had long been torn

apart. Smoke and dust filled every street. Filthy mud and slowly cooling blood soaked the city, and more twisted sights kept covering everything.

“Commander, they are everywhere!”

At the crossroads of Fireplace Street, a Guard Corps squad that had once been trapped in the mist was now using the firepower of a Steam Walker to sweep the freaks that appeared on the street. The soldiers had not even had time to cheer when the thick fog faded before more monsters and horror phenomena dragged them into a new fierce fight.

“Then fire everywhere!” the squad commander roared. He shot into the distance as he rushed to the feet of the Steam Walker and to the side of the signaler. “Can you reach the other squads?”

“Squads Seven, Six, and Four are still missing!” the signaler shouted. “Almost a quarter of the squads vanished in the earlier fog, Commander!”

“Keep calling until someone answers, or until reinforcements come,” the commander said, slapping the signaler’s helmet and turning to look into the distance. “The fog is gone. Hold on. The situation is changing – this may be the last attack!”

The machine gun turret of the Steam Walker roared in a long burst and tore another distant Steam Walker into pieces. As that huge machine crashed to the ground, a vast amount of filthy sludge also burst from its machinery bay, splashing onto the street like horrible innards.

The warriors once again forced up their courage – or maybe they just let numbness keep driving their exhausted limbs. The commander spoke words of encouragement he did not even believe himself, then raised his head to look into the distance again.

He saw the two Silent Cathedrals standing high on the mountaintop. On one side of the city-state, the ground seemed to curl and rise in a strange way.

Huge, unfamiliar building clusters were slowly rising out of the city. Layer upon layer of buildings piled over the streets he knew. Twisted, slanted high towers spread out of far-off structures, like hateful bone growths sprouting from giants, stretching and growing in the sky.

Countless streams of sludge were flowing out of those high, lifted buildings, pouring down as if to swallow the whole city.

“O Lord of Death…” At the top of the Silent Cathedral, Bishop Ivan looked down at the city-state that was slowly twisting and being devoured by huge Visions. At last he could not help but speak in a low voice. “Is today the day it all ends…”

He looked into the distance, but could only see vast darkness surging up from all sides. The original City Hall on the opposite hilltop had, at some unknown time, become wrapped in strange thorns. In that thicket of thorns stood another Silent Cathedral in a hazy way. At the foot of the hill, row after row of buildings rocked and piled up, rising in a heap. The houses took on a shape that made one’s skin crawl, like the limbs of soft-bodied creatures.

Outside the city-state, the whole sea was slowly being covered by an ominous black. That darkness was like a huge mirror, and in the mirror another Frostholm slowly appeared. It was like looking at another world through a bent mirror. That “Frostholm” looked twisted and wrong everywhere, full of errors that felt almost right and full of crawling, pitch-black malice.

The huge city of mirror world was rising from the Deep Sea, corrupting everything in the Mortal Realm and in the unreal at the same time.

“Archbishop!” A High Deacon ran out from the terrace door and came to stand behind Bishop Ivan. “The last reserve forces have gathered. The

Silent monks and the Guardians will protect the Great Cathedral until the final moment!”

“Agatha still has not come back?”

“We still cannot contact Lady Gatekeeper,” the High Deacon said quickly. “The exploration team that went down the shaft with her reported that the Gatekeeper vanished after entering a strange stone wall. There has been no word since. Now the mine has been swallowed by darkness. I fear…”

“The Gatekeeper will not fall so easily. Agatha will finish her mission… she will finish it for sure,” Bishop Ivan said calmly.

The High Deacon hesitated. “Archbishop, you should take shelter…”

“Take shelter? Hide in some safe prayer room in a chapel? Or take a ship and flee this city?” Bishop Ivan turned around and slowly shook his head. “I do not need to take shelter. I will stay here. You go and command the Guardian units at the foot of the hill. Move every commoner you can up the mountain. Hold on as long as you can.”

The High Deacon hesitated a few more seconds, then finally nodded hard. “Yes, Archbishop!”

The High Deacon withdrew, and the old bishop was alone again on the terrace.

He raised his head and gazed at the other great Cathedral that was wrapped in thorns, the one that looked like a shadow of the Silent Cathedral.

That great Cathedral was dead and still. No clerics could be seen inside.

It was only a mirror world, but its appearance meant that the “Inversion” of that mirror world Frostholm had reached the final step.

“Agatha… you should still be somewhere, carrying out your duty…”

Bishop Ivan spoke softly, as if talking to himself, yet also as if gently reminding a junior with whom he had already lost contact.

He slowly raised his hand and undid the rich robes that stood for the archbishop’s authority. Then he took off his crown and set it on the rail beside him.

“Then you should still remember that the Saints of Bartok never stop before death…”

With the fine robes and the crown of Your Eminence taken off, layers of bandages were revealed. Ivan reached up, felt around, and slowly loosened a knot near his neck.

“We face filth with flesh and blood. When life ends, we guard our faith with bodies that do not rest. And when even the body ends…”

The bandages came loose. It was as if a container that had been sealed and pressed down for decades finally broke free. Under the bandages there was not some broken body – there had long been no body at all.

Under them there was only pale ash and smoke.

“We still have burning ash.”

The bandages fell away. Fluttering bone ash flew out from the edge of the terrace, turning into fine white smoke that slowly spread and covered the sky over Frostholm.

Chapter 432: The Call of Fire

In the Harbor district, Lister, who was commanding the garrison to hold off the attack while trying to keep the Harbor running, suddenly looked up and stared blankly toward the city-state.

Inside the city-state, strange twisted buildings were surging up and appearing above ordinary streets. In the distance, the land was warping and flipping over. Faint thorn-shaped phantoms covered the mountains, and chaotic light and shadow were descending out of nothing. Yet in the middle of this terrifying, eerie scene, some fine, pale “dust” suddenly began to drift down.

That pale dust appeared in the sky out of nowhere. It floated down like the first snow at the start of winter. It passed through overlapping phantoms and twisted, alien streets, and little by little fell onto the streets of Frostholm. It seemed weightless, yet endless.

Where the motes of dust fell, the city-state that had turned vague and chaotic because of overlapping phantoms suddenly looked clear-cut again. It lasted only for a moment, and the change was small, but Lister clearly saw a boundary appear again between the illusions and the real streets.

But he had no time to think about what this meant, or even to think about what would happen to him in the next minute.

The roar of Steam Walkers opening fire and the thunder of distant Coastal Guns pulled him back to the Mortal Realm.

“Hold those freaks outside the docks!” Lister ran along the walkways between buildings and through the defensive line built from Steam Walkers and makeshift barricades. He shouted to the soldiers and officers: “Keep the fuel depots and ammunition routes clear! The Harbor must not fall!”

Smoke spread in all directions. The air carried the smell of blood, machine oil, and the sharp stench that rose when foul sludge dried out. One Steam Walker was destroyed, and at once another spider-like machine rushed out from behind cover to hold the fragile line.

Inside that line lay the battered docks and the many teams running between the Harbor’s buildings.

Lister climbed to a higher spot and looked toward the docks.

When the monsters had first poured out of the thick fog, the Harbor had almost fallen. He and his soldiers had paid a heavy price to clear the corruption inside the Harbor’s area and to build a line on the road leading into the city. They had held that line until now.

According to the last external transmission, this was already the only Harbor in Frostholm still operating. The other Harbors were either still fiercely contested, already lost, or unable to function because their key facilities had been badly damaged.

He had to keep it running at any cost. The sea front was already on the brink. If they lost this last coastal support, the City Navy would truly be finished.

But with another terrifying twisted city slowly invading the Mortal Realm… could they really hold this place?

Lister turned back and took one last look at the deformed land swelling up inside the city like a bloated, festering wound. He forced himself to ignore

how it was slowly spreading toward the Harbor, then left the line and returned to the defense command post.

It was just as busy here. Officers and staff officers were worn out and frantic. The reports coming in from all sides were bleak, and the calls and beeps from all the radios never stopped.

A radio operator sat in the corner, his voice hoarse as he repeated into the set: “To all ships in coastal waters, this is East Harbor. We are still here. Repeat, we are still here—this is the only safe resupply port. Do not approach any other Harbor…”

Lister walked straight up to a subordinate. “How is the resupply pier?”

“The Laurel is resupplying ammunition and repairing its feed elevators. Her sister ship has lost power and is being towed back by barges. Our ammunition, fuel, and fresh water are still sufficient, but the crane at Pier Four was destroyed, so that side is paralyzed…”

Lister listened with a dark face. Then hurried footsteps came from the side. Another junior officer rushed to his side, looking tense. “Commander, there is a situation…”

“There are situations everywhere,” Lister said loudly. “Report directly!”

“Yes. A ship is requesting to enter port for repairs. It is… from the Sea Mist Fleet,” the junior officer said, his eyes complicated. “The Undying on board say their transmission system has failed, and the equipment on the ship cannot handle it.”

Lister froze for a moment. Three seconds later, he clenched his teeth. “Let them enter the port. Help them repair it as fast as possible.”

“Yes, Commander.”

The subordinate left. Lister walked quickly to the window and looked out toward the sea.

A warship trailing thick smoke was slowly approaching the repair dock. The Queen of Frostholm's flag flew at its bow. Farther out on the sea, wreckage floated everywhere.

"Half a century… and this flag finally returned to Frostholm like this…"

Lister muttered without thinking.

But the next second, a sudden commotion sounded from the corridor and cut off the Harbor's defense commander's sigh.

"What now?" He turned his head and shouted.

A nervous soldier pushed the door open in a hurry, looking very awkward as he spoke to the commander-in-chief. "Commander! There are two… ordinary citizens, two young ladies. I don't know how they got in, but they insist on talking to you…"

"Ordinary citizens? Send them to the shel—" Lister started to speak on reflex, but before he could finish, the sound of scuffling rushed in from the corridor. Right after that he heard a young girl's noisy voice outside—

"Get the hell out of the way! Move it! Time is precious! What was that word again… window, oh, window interval, it only lasts this damn little while!"

Lister looked up in shock. The next second, he saw two young ladies force their way past the soldiers and barge into this crucial command room.

One was short and thin, dressed in a black cotton dress, yet she pushed two burly soldiers away from the doorway with one shove. The other was a bit taller, wearing a plain brown coat and cotton skirt, and she looked a little nervous.

They both looked only sixteen or seventeen. The thin one even looked younger.

“Leave at once,” Lister said at once, his irritation making his tone harsh. “This is not a place for you to fool around. If you got separated from the evacuees, then—”

“You’re the boss here? We have something important,” the thin young lady cut him off loudly before he could finish. “Is there somewhere nearby you’re not using for now? We need to start a fire…”

“Start a fire?” Lister froze for a moment, then realized this was a terrible joke. He could not understand why two random commoners would come here to cause trouble at a time like this. His professional instincts snapped him awake. He shouted at once, “soldiers, restrain them!”

Several soldiers rushed in at once to seize the two strangers. The short girl started hopping as she shouted, “We really do have something important! The angle from here is perfect, we just need a patch of open ground! You…”

She suddenly stopped. She stared wide-eyed out the window, as if she had just seen something.

“Hey! Over there works! The whole avenue is empty, and it leads straight to the coastline!” The girl jumped high, and even two or three soldiers could not hold her down. Then she turned her head and called to her companion, “Nina, you go there. With that and the two arson points we found to the south just now, the city side will definitely be enough!”

“Ah… okay!” The young lady called Nina answered at once. Then she turned back, bowed slightly to Lister with an awkward, apologetic look, and said, “S-sorry, mister. My friend is not very good at talking to people. We’ll leave now…”

Lister stared, the absurd scene making his mind go blank, but he still stepped forward on instinct. “Stop, you—”

His words never finished.

Because something even more absurd happened.

Heat suddenly surged around the young girl in front of him. In the blink of an eye she turned into a leaping, blinding arc of fire. The flame rose in the room, and its glare felt as if just looking at it could set a person’s soul on fire. The next second, the flame flew toward the open window, like a shooting star flying backward, and shot straight at a high platform near the Harbor district.

Lister stared in shock, but before he could process it, the flame suddenly rushed back into the room.

The flame bent toward him in a bow, outlining the shape of a girl. A polite voice came from within it, crackling with sparks: “Thank you for protecting the city. I’m leaving! Goodbye!”

The arc of flame shot out of the room again.

“Bye-bye!”

In the room, the short girl also shouted again and again. Then a pitch-black rift suddenly opened beside her. Shadows surged inside it and yanked her away, making her vanish into thin air before everyone’s eyes.

“What… what the hell…”

Lister stared at this scene, stunned and dazed, then ran to the open window on reflex. He only caught a glimpse of an arc of blazing fire shooting straight up into the sky in the distance.

And beneath that flame, the coastline bathed in its harsh light… suddenly burst into fire!

“The Frostholm coast is aflame!”

On the Sea Mist’s lookout platform, an Undying sailor raised a speaking trumpet and shouted.

Waves rose and fell, and the cold wind curled back on itself. Tyrian stood at the edge of the bow deck like a lone reef. In his single eye, the Frostholm coast was reflected, with several great fires now burning there.

A bright flame jumped over the city, constantly igniting the empty areas along its edges: tall cliffs, rocks jutting from the water, fallen watchtowers, and shattered gun emplacements. The burning points slowly linked together, like a row of endless candlesticks.

Around the Sea Mist, the vast sea itself was burning in great patches.

Debris left by the replica fleet burned. Ships of the Sea Mist Fleet and the City Navy burned. Leaked fuel burned.

The whole sea was being set on fire by war.

In that burning sea, the twisted, eerie light and shadow of the mirror world world were reflected: the Ghost fleet rising without end, the strange and terrifying mirror world Frostholm in the distance, and the boundless darkness filling the space around those twisted entities.

“Captain!” First Mate Aiden ran over and shouted beside Tyrian, “The last barrel of fuel has been dumped. The flames around us are about to reach the ship!”

“I know,” Tyrian said calmly, and a faint smile slowly appeared on his face. “How is Frostholm’s navy reacting?”

“They also did what we told them and lit their spare whale oil, but they still have no idea what we’re trying to do. They are just following orders in total confusion. They hope we can give them an explanation.”

“An explanation…”

Tyrian muttered softly, then slowly raised his hand and pointed around the Sea Mist, at the sea that was being covered by thicker and thicker darkness and growing more and more eerie.

“Aiden, what does this sea look like to you?”

Aiden paused, then lifted his head and looked around.

In the next second, his expression slowly froze, even showing a hint of fear.

At some point, the waves and wind on the sea had quickly died down. Endless darkness made the whole stretch of water slowly take on a mirror-like sheen.

Flames burned before that mirror, from the Frostholm coast all the way to the zone where the fleets were locked in battle. The chain of war fires looked like ritual candles set before a mirror.

The wind, waves, and gunfire on the sea seemed to fade all at once. Everything grew distant, as if it came from another world. In that eerie, brief silence, Aiden heard his captain speak softly.

“Father said that if we ever wanted to seek him out, we should find a mirror and light flames in front of it.”

Tyrian slowly spread his arms, facing the sea that was turning into a black mirror.

“The fire is lit. Are you there?”

Thus, the sea around Frostholm opened its eyes.

“I am here.”

Chapter 433: Burning Away

In that instant, Frostholm truly became a city floating on a mirror.

The sea itself was that mirror.

Reflected in it was not only the twisted, terrifying mirror world city, but also a pair of eyes burning with fire, and a presence larger than the city-state itself—so large it seemed to match the whole Frostholm sea region.

The divine authority of fire shifted in an instant. Every flame burning on and around that mirror became a medium that spread and magnified that power.

“Commander! Commander! The fire… the fire!”

The horrified shout of a junior officer snapped Lister out of his daze. He jolted fully awake and followed the sound to the window. He saw the whole coastline burning, and even the entire sea set alight. Rolling flames rose up, and then a ghostly green glow flowed out of the fire like water and quickly dyed his whole field of view.

The spirit form flames rising from all directions seemed to carry a power that shook the soul, making Lister step back on reflex. But in the next second he saw that even the flames inside the gas lamps set into the nearby wall were quietly tinged with a layer of ghostly green.

A deep rumble came from far away, as if it shook the whole city. It was mixed with loud creaks like some enormous thing being torn and broken apart. Everyone in the command post heard the booming noise.

Someone turned toward the city in the direction of the sound and saw that the grotesque twisted structures that had almost covered the whole city were cracking open piece by piece. Even greater tongues of fire burst from the cracks. In the midst of that vast spirit form blaze, countless black substances were slowly being burned away.

Near the Harbor defense zone, an exhausted city Guard Corps hid behind a crumbling barricade and watched as the twisted buildings in the distance split apart. Hundreds and thousands of deformed, writhing things fled from the cracks, but flames chased after them and burned them into black ash.

At the foot of the central mountain, the Guardian troops were locked in a life-and-death struggle with invading replica freaks. Suddenly, a phantom army charged out of the chaotic light and shadow. This force wore Guard Corps uniforms from half a century ago, the uniforms of the Queen's Guard. They rushed into the streets, shouting the Queen of Frostholm's name, and fought to the death against the twisted monsters pouring into the Mortal Realm.

At the last line of defense in front of the Silent Cathedral, the High Deacon was organizing the priests to fight the monsters flooding into the square. The tongues of fire spewing from the Steam Walkers and the pale flame released by the Silent monks wove together into a net that barely held back the monsters and the invading sludge.

"Hold them back!" the High Deacon shouted hoarsely. At the edge of his vision, fine pale ash was drifting down from above the Silent Cathedral like falling first snow. "Block the Cathedral doors! Block—"

A thunderous boom and a tremor that felt like it shook the mountains suddenly hit. The High Deacon almost fell in the earth-shattering impact. A thorn of congealed sludge, full of malice, shot at him through a gap in the line.

But just as it was about to pierce him, a streak of ghostly green flame appeared in midair and turned the wicked attack into ash.

The High Deacon looked up in shock and saw a figure floating in front of him.

She wore tattered black robes like those of an ascetic. Her body was covered in cracks large and small, and flames surged through her like boiling, eternal blood.

“Agatha… Gatekeeper?”

The High Deacon stared at the figure before him, feeling that she was both familiar and strange. He said her name, then saw more unfamiliar figures appear beside the Gatekeeper. Each of them was wrapped in ghostly green spirit form flames.

“I’m back,” Agatha said, turning her head. Two points of fire flickered in her empty eye sockets, and her voice crackled with sparks. “Take the rest of your people and fall back, or find a safe place and stand firm.”

“Stand firm?” the High Deacon repeated in confusion, not understanding what she meant for a moment. “And… why have you become like this…”

Agatha did not answer him. As the deep rumbling grew denser and louder, she turned the other way and looked toward the sea outside the city.

Thick smoke rose over the sea. The clouds hung low and black. The ocean was dark as a mirror, and a vast, nameless presence was… rising from that mirror.

Two huge green lights, almost like suns, slowly rose through the smoke and clouds. An outline beyond human imagination took shape in that smoke and cloud, as if the sea and the sky themselves were bulging and gathering into a form. The sight made even Agatha, who had already stopped breathing long ago, feel suffocated again.

It was a suffocation of the soul.

“God of Death…” The High Deacon could hardly endure the crushing pressure. His body, which he had just managed to get upright, shook and collapsed again. “That is… what is that?!”

Agatha only tilted her head slightly, her tone helpless. “I did remind you to find a safe place and stand firm.”

The High Deacon could no longer hear what the Gatekeeper was saying to him. As the outline in the clouds rapidly solidified, he finally understood what it was.

It was a figure rising from the endless sea, a being using the whole Frostholm sea region as a medium to project itself into the Mortal Realm.

The two green fires blazing in the clouds like suns were actually its eyes. The curling, surging clouds were its breath. The huge shadow slowly lifting inside the smoke… was its arm.

Now that hand was reaching toward Frostholm.

“My Lord!”

Someone cried out in the square.

But the hand, though it looked slow, moved faster than any shout or prayer. It had already passed over the sea, over the waters where the Sea Mist Fleet, Frostholm navy, and replica fleet were fighting, and over the city’s coast. It reached into Frostholm’s depths as if reaching into smoke.

In the next second, the arm began to rise slowly, as if lifting a mass of hundreds of millions of tons, inch by inch.

And rising with that arm was a mirror world city that was being peeled away from Mortal Realm Frostholm.

All the twisted buildings, the curled and swollen land, the thorns covering the mountains, and all those blasphemous things that half-mimicked the Mortal Realm yet overwrote it with horror were torn bit by bit out of the Frostholm city-state by that hand.

mirror world Frostholm had risen up into the Mortal Realm. Now it floated far higher than its Creators had ever planned, and it was still rising.

Agatha laughed, more happily than ever before.

With mirror world Frostholm torn free from the city and still rising, the scene looked like an evil spirit being driven out of a body that a malevolent spirit had invaded. That “evil spirit” was slowly lifted up toward the clouds by a gigantic arm.

Deep in the thick clouds, the two green fireballs burning like suns swayed slightly. A vague but stern and awe-inspiring face seemed to be looking down.

Many tiny sounds came from the palm.

Some were real noises, but most sounded like vibrations echoing on the level of thought—the howls echoing in a pile of twisted wreckage, and the stubborn, fanatical fantasies and delusions that clung to the mirror world city.

Duncan looked through the clouds at his own palm. The mirror world city there was like a swollen, misshapen lump of flesh. The streets that had clumsily imitated the Mortal Realm were quickly reverting into their original state as filthy mud. Between the bloated, twisted streets, hills, and buildings, tiny thorns kept pulsing in and out. Faint sparks, almost too small to see, flickered in the center of the mass. The tangled obsessions of hundreds and thousands of mad believers buzzed there, making a noise like a swarm of flies.

Mixed into them were fear, fury, unwillingness, and pure malice.

Were those fanatics still trying to preach their Doomsday theories? Or were they just trying to find a reasonable explanation for the disaster they had brought on themselves?

Duncan listened for a while, then lowered his gaze.

“You fools don’t know the first thing about a large-scale sacrificial rite.”

His gaze focused on the lump of mirror world city, and the whole city began to burn in his sight, in the palm of his hand.

Innumerable ash and green flowing fire fell from the sky like a storm pouring down from the clouds.

The hand, as huge as a city, slowly closed into a fist. mirror world Frostholm, already burned to ash in its palm, turned into powder with a terrifying grinding sound. Countless remaining pieces were flung out over the Frostholm sea region. They fell into the ocean, onto the coast, onto every place Tyrian could see.

But almost all the fallen relics avoided Frostholm’s main island and the sea where the Sea Mist Fleet and Frostholm navy were still active.

Tyrian looked around.

All the replica ships were collapsing quickly.

It was finally over.

He let out a slow breath.

First Mate Aiden stood beside him. The bald giant of a man looked up at the sky, but he could only see a small part of that huge figure’s outline.

Aiden’s body was still trembling.

“Any thoughts?” Tyrian turned his head and looked at his first mate with a half-smile.

Aiden fumbled a pipe out of his coat, but his hands shook so much he could not light it. After a long moment he put the pipe down again, his voice trembling a little. “The old captain… he won’t mind that we fought him before, right?”

Tyrian only smiled and took a rolled cigarette from his own coat.

“Father won’t care about such small things.”

But the Frost Sea Pirate Lord’s hands shook for a long time too, and he never managed to light his cigarette.

Chapter 434:

mirror world turned to ash. The darkness began to fade. The phantom of the Queen Guard Corps vanished. The Profane Constructs that had invaded the city-state broke apart one after another, turning into black sludge that dried up at once. The gunfire and cannon blasts all over the city-state fell silent with them – what took their place was an unspeakable fear and stillness that covered the whole city.

Everyone could see that vast presence, the one standing out in the Boundless Sea, looking down at the city-state from within the clouds.

Just a few minutes ago, mirror world Frostholm had turned to ash in the hand of that giant, and no one could guess what would happen next.

Only the eerie green flame that spread across the whole city and the surface of the sea still burned fiercely. Yet these flames did not hurt anyone. They only brushed over the Mortal Realm like phantoms. When they touched you, all you felt was a harmless warmth.

Agatha lowered her head and casually helped the pale High Deacon to his feet. The flames burning on Agatha’s arm made the High Deacon a little nervous, but compared with the mood hanging over the city, that small fear did not matter.

“The next part…” The High Deacon looked even paler. He looked at Agatha, at the eerie green spirit flame burning on her body, the same flame that filled the whole city. His voice still shook as he asked: “What will happen next?”

Agatha thought for a moment and shook her head: “I do not know.”

The High Deacon stared: “You do not know?!”

“…I did not ask,” Agatha said calmly. “The situation was urgent. I had no other choice.”

The High Deacon was dumbfounded. He had many questions. He wanted to ask where that giant above the sea had come from, what these flames in the city really were, and why Agatha looked like this now. But for the moment, he could not ask even one of them.

Agatha no longer cared about the High Deacon’s reaction. She only tilted her head a little and watched the last fine pale ashes drift down onto her shoulder.

At some point, the ash drifting over the city-state had stopped. What landed on her shoulder seemed to be the very last piece. In a daze, Agatha felt as if someone had patted her on the shoulder.

“I have to go,” she heard someone speak beside her ear. “My journey in this world is over. A longer road is still waiting for me.”

“Safe travels, Bishop Ivan.”

A wind blew in from far away. It passed through the silent main doors of the great cathedral, swept across the square before the doors, and caught that light ash, letting it quietly scatter in the wind.

…

On top of the clock tower behind the Cathedral, Shirley, in a black dress, looked down at the streets. She sat on a section of wall that stuck out from the eaves, her legs dangling outside as she swung them back and forth in boredom and muttered: “It got quiet…”

“Everyone looks scared…” Nina stood on the small platform behind Shirley. As she spoke, she looked up at the sky. “I was scared too…”

“Who would not be scared after seeing that?” Shirley shrank her neck and carefully stared at the huge, hazy figure over the distant sea. “I never thought Mr. Duncan would solve this trouble in this way in the end – it made even more noise than last time in Pland.”

“Uncle Duncan said the root of Frostholm’s crisis was that mirror world, so to solve the problem you had to get rid of mirror world completely. Sealing it or stopping the cultists’ ritual would only keep people safe for a while. The only way to settle it once and for all was to pull mirror world up by the roots, drag it into the Mortal Realm, and burn it,” Nina said very seriously. “But mirror world was too big, so he needed a big enough ‘fire ground’…”

“Alright, alright, I get it. You are very good at setting fires, right? I will be sure to mention this to Mr. Duncan later,” Shirley said as she waved her hands again and again. Then she looked up with some doubt. “But, back to the point… what is Mr. Duncan doing now? Is the matter not already settled? When will he come back?”

When she heard this, Nina looked up at the huge figure above the sea outside the city, thought for a moment, and said: “Then I will go up and ask?”

“Go, go,” Shirley said quickly, waving her hand. “When you get up there, do not forget to tell Mr. Duncan that our homework got eaten by Abyssal Hounds…”

Before she even finished speaking, Nina had already turned into a bright arc of flame in midair, then shot straight toward the shadow that covered the sky outside the city.

…

From a height where he could look over the entire sea around Frostholm, Duncan let his gaze pass through gaps in the clouds and quietly watched the sea and the city below.

The sea had no end and stretched into the far distance. The city-state was like a round disc floating on the water, alone in the daylight. At the place where sea and sky met, he could faintly see a grand wall of mist. The mist stood like a wall, forming a dim arc that ringed the whole border of civilization.

It was a view he had never had before. He had never looked at this world from this place, and he guessed that no one else in this world had ever done anything like it either.

He could feel that the “flame” that held up his current form was slowly going out over the sea and the city. He could not stay standing in the sky like this for long, but before the stored power ran dry, he still wanted to look a little more.

Just then, a little tongue of flame shot out from the clouds and came into Duncan’s sight.

That small flame hopped between the clouds like a light swallow. As it drew near, Duncan heard Nina’s voice in his ear: “Uncle Duncan! What are you doing?”

“I am watching this world,” Duncan said softly with a smile to the little flame. He raised a finger and let her dance on his fingertip. “How did you get up here?”

“Shirley told me to come up. She was curious about what you were doing,” Nina said happily as the flame wavered on Duncan’s fingertip. Even though her current form had swelled into a blaze larger than the clock tower, in

Duncan’s eyes she was still very small. “You said you are watching the world? What is so interesting about it?”

Duncan smiled and lifted his chin: “Look, down there.”

The little flame swayed to the side.

“…Wow.”

“It is amazing, is it not?” Duncan said softly. “No one has ever looked down on the Boundless Sea and the cities on it from this height, or seen that distant mist. It is so huge that even with my view right now, I feel short of breath when I look at it.”

Nina thought very hard: “…But if it was a normal-sized human standing at the edge of the Eternal Veil, they would not feel anything. They could not see the whole thing.”

Duncan paused for a moment, then suddenly laughed.

“Yes, you are right. When an ordinary person really stands before that wall of mist, they will not even notice this feeling of pressure and suffocation, because they cannot see all of it. We are up high, and we see too much.”

“Uncle Duncan, why do I feel like… there is some other meaning in what you are saying?”

Duncan did not answer Nina’s question. He just stared into the distance. After a while, he suddenly spoke: “Are you not curious? About what is on the other side of that mist?”

“…The books say the mist has no end. There is no other side. Outside, there is only mist.”

Duncan looked at his fingertip: “That is what the books say. What do you think?”

“…I think the books are just the scholars’ guesses. Mr. Morris said that everything about things outside the civilized world is only scholars’ guesses. Research means following a guess and testing it,” Nina said happily as she shared her thoughts. “The other side of that mist might even be another world!”

Then she stopped, as if she had just realized something: “Ah! Uncle Duncan, are you planning to walk through that thick mist? Are you really going to try it? We are very close to the northern border here, and you are so high up now, so maybe you really could…”

“Sadly, it is not possible,” Duncan said, gently shaking his head and cutting off the excited Nina. “I cannot keep this state for long, and I cannot leave this sea like this at all. A ritual has limits. Right now all we can do is watch from here.”

Nina seemed a little down for a moment. After a while, she spoke again in a careful tone: “Then can I… go over and take a look? I can fly in the sky now~”

“But you can only fly for a short time. You know your own limits very well,” Duncan said, shaking his head again. “And I do not advise you to do it. We know too little about that thick mist. Having a brave spirit is not the same as acting rashly.”

Nina stayed quiet for a moment, then drew out her voice: “Oh – so we really can only stand here and look.”

“The first step of a journey is to look into the distance,” Duncan said, the corners of his mouth curling up. He could feel the flame that held him up begin to fade quickly. This draining form had reached its limit, but before his projected body scattered, he still smiled. “And we should not only look far away, Nina. Did you notice the shape of the city-state? Such a neat

circle, so tidy that it does not look natural. And the sea below, deep and wide. Even now we do not know what is down at the bottom…

“The cultists are sure this world will end and that they can build a New World. The Holy See is sure that following the guidance of the Four Gods is the only way to keep the world forever. But there are too many things in this world that we do not know. Whether it is the cultists, the Church of the True Gods, or the scholars in each city-state, everyone’s view of everything on the Boundless Sea is only one side of the truth.”

Between sea and sky, the giant’s huge body quietly faded. The sea, which had been like a mirror, slowly returned to waves.

A streak of fire fell from the clouds back toward the city-state.

But Duncan and Nina kept talking:

“Alright, Nina, go back. We still have a lot to do.”

“Oh… ah, right! Uncle Duncan! I forgot to tell you. Our homework got eaten by Abyssal Hounds, mine and Shirley’s!”

“…It is fine. Mr. Morris and I will prepare new homework for you.”

Chapter 435:

That towering body faded in the clouds.

The wind slowly grew calm again. The smoke of battle still needed time to fade. After the Shadows withdrew, they left behind a city-state full of scars.

“There is a survivor here too! A little young lady!”

The excited shout broke the quiet in the graveyard. A Guardian warrior pushed open the door of the Warden’s hut and found a girl curled up inside.

Cold wind blew in through the open door, carrying the smell of smoke. Annie lifted her head in a daze and looked at the black-clad guard in the doorway. For a moment, she seemed to see another person appear behind the young warrior, a bent figure with always gloomy eyes.

She stood up in confusion and took a step forward without thinking. She stumbled and ran toward the doorway, trying to catch that bent figure.

She grabbed at nothing. Her foot slipped, and then she felt someone catch the collar of her coat from behind. The Guardian warrior had caught the girl who had tried to run past him and almost fallen. He bent down toward her and asked: “Are you alright, young lady? What is your name? Why are you in the graveyard?”

But Annie seemed not to hear his voice at all. She only raised her head and slowly looked around, searching for the old man she had just seen.

The bent old man stood not far away. He had already turned his back to them and waved. Then he slowly walked toward the path deeper in the

graveyard. At the far end of that path, an unusual tall figure stood faintly and quietly.

That figure wore a pitch-black robe that made people think of the veil of night. The body under the robe was wrapped in bandages, and the figure held a long staff that looked as if it had been carved from dead wood. The figure looked just like the Warden who stood before the gate of Bartok in the Church's books.

The old man walked up to the Warden. The two of them seemed to speak a few words, then vanished together like phantoms at the end of the path.

Annie stared blankly in that direction. She stood still in the cold wind, without crying or moving.

The black-clad guard beside her grew worried: "What is wrong? Little young lady? What are you looking for?"

"She may be looking for this," another voice suddenly said from the nearby path, along with the sound of boots stepping on snow.

Annie turned her head without thinking.

A nun was walking toward them, holding two things in her hands – a Gatekeeper's cane that already looked badly worn, and a hunting rifle that seemed a little familiar.

"Your protector is gone," the nun said as she stopped in front of Annie. She slowly squatted and set the two things on the ground. "I am sorry. We cannot let you see him again. There was only ash at the site."

Annie stared at the Gatekeeper's cane and the rifle on the ground. After a few seconds, she bent down, picked them up, and held them carefully in her arms.

"I know," she whispered. "Grandpa Caretaker left with the Gatekeeper…"

“Do not touch the gun,” the black-clad Guardian warrior said, reaching out without thinking to stop her. “It is dan…”

“There are no bullets left,” the nun said softly, shaking her head. “Let her hold it for a while. They may have known each other.”

The Guardian warrior hesitated for a moment, then drew his hand back and turned his head to take in the graveyard.

Filthy, dried black sludge covered the path and ringed the Warden’s hut. Dirty snow and that mud mixed together and blanketed the whole graveyard.

How many monsters had tried to attack this place? How much filth had fallen on the snow here? Now that the Shadows had gone, it seemed that no one could ever know.

A cool, light touch fell on him. The Guardian looked up and saw snowflakes slowly falling from the sky. It was not ash this time, but real snow.

With the swirling snow came a glow in the sky. It was the light of the Sun. The heavy clouds still blocked it, but that hazy glow still showed that it was there.

The Sun had returned.

The mechanical roar of a steam engine drew near from outside the graveyard. A steam car stopped at the gate. A nearby Guardian squad heard the noise and moved toward the car, then, in surprise, saluted the person who stepped down.

Footsteps came toward the Warden’s hut. The young black-clad guard saw who it was, turned at once, and saluted. Then he asked in confusion: “Gatekeeper, you are…”

“I am here to check on the graveyards.”

Annie, who was still staring blankly as she held the Gatekeeper’s cane and the rifle, heard the voice beside her. She finally snapped out of her daze, lifted her head without thinking, and looked toward the sound.

A lady in a black priest’s robe stood on the path.

Her skin was pale, and a calm yet icy aura hung around her. Annie did not yet understand what that feeling was, but it made her think of the cold fog on the sea. At the same time, she saw that the skin the lady showed was covered with wounds of all sizes. There was no blood in the wounds. They looked like cracks in a doll.

A strip of black cloth was wrapped over the lady’s eyes.

The lady seemed to be blind, yet Annie felt that the woman’s “gaze” still rested on her. It was a calm and gentle look, passing through the thick black cloth and casting a gaze on her.

Annie took a long time to recognize the lady.

But the lady had clearly recognized her from the start.

“I know you. You are Annie,” Agatha said as she bent down and gently ruffled Annie’s hair. Then her gaze fell to the rifle and Gatekeeper’s cane in the girl’s hands. After two seconds of silence, Agatha stood up and spoke to the priest who had come with her: “The mines were the first places to be invaded. These graveyards around the upper city’s mining area blocked many monsters that were rushing toward the nearby districts.”

“All the Gravekeepers and most of the Guardians stationed around the graveyards died in battle,” the nun beside them said slowly. “The city-state’s Guard Corps in this area also took heavy losses.”

Agatha listened in silence, then gave a quiet benediction.

“Gatekeeper,” the black-clad guard could not help speaking. “There are many dead and wounded in the city-state now. We need to watch for secondary disasters in the domains of death, fear, and obsession. We may need several large-scale soul-soothing rituals, and the Great Cathedral still has not…”

“I am acting as Archbishop for now. Do not worry about the soul-soothing rituals,” Agatha said calmly. “Bishop Ivan has already left. He has a new journey.”

The black-clad guard froze for a moment. Shock and disbelief crossed his eyes. It seemed that only now did he notice that Agatha’s outfit had changed.

The Gatekeeper had taken off the black coat that stood for force. In its place, she wore a robe that belonged more to the clergy.

That change showed that her role and duties had changed.

“Do not worry. I still bear the duties of Gatekeeper, and I will still command the Guardian forces until the Church’s headquarters chooses a new Archbishop or appoints a new Gatekeeper to take my place. At that time, I may become the formal Bishop of this city-state,” Agatha said. Even though she had lost her eyes, she still seemed to have a sharp gaze and had noticed how her subordinate reacted. She explained with patience: “For now, keeping order in the city-state is more important than anything.”

“Yes… Gatekeeper.”

The young black-clad guard lowered his head. After a brief pause, he still chose to use the familiar title “Gatekeeper” for his superior.

Agatha did not care about such small things. She turned her “gaze” toward Annie again.

“Go home,” she said gently. “Your mother is safe. She is waiting for you.”

Annie hesitated for a second at first, but when Agatha mentioned her mother, Annie nodded at once.

But just as she was about to leave with the Guardians, she suddenly stopped.

“Grandpa Caretaker… just went with the Gatekeeper,” she said, raising her head to look at Agatha. “Ah, I mean the Gatekeeper from ‘the other side’ like the books say.”

Agatha frowned a little.

Annie thought Agatha did not believe her, so she quickly raised her hand and pointed toward the path deep in the graveyard: “They left from there…”

Agatha raised her head and looked in the direction Annie pointed, deep in thought.

In the place where her eyes lay hidden under the black cloth, a faint green fire seemed to flash.

A moment later, she lowered her head and faced Annie’s eyes.

“Do you… want to become a Guardian?”

Annie stared, a little lost. She did not seem to fully understand what that meant yet.

But after a few seconds, she seemed to realize it faintly: “Do you mean, like you or Grandpa Caretaker?”

“That may take many years,” Agatha said, and a small smile seemed to appear on her face. Then she shook her head gently. “Do not think too much about it yet. It is a little early for me to tell you this now. Go home first. If you really want to become a Guardian, you must at least get into the Church’s most basic school.”

Annie half understood and half did not. Then, unwilling to part with them, she handed the rifle and the Gatekeeper's cane to the black-clad guard beside her.

"…If I become a Guardian, can I have Grandpa Caretaker's rifle and Gatekeeper's cane?" she asked.

She suddenly turned her head and looked at Agatha very seriously.

After a moment, Agatha nodded slightly: "…If you still feel this way in three years, I agree."

Annie left.

The graveyard grew quiet again.

"…Are you serious? That child is still too young. We cannot see any real talent yet. To inherit a veteran's Gatekeeper's cane, you need more than just finishing the normal Guardian training…" the guard said.

"She can see the guides from the world of the dead," Agatha said slowly as she cast her gaze toward the path at the end of the graveyard. "Just like I did back then."

The young black-clad guard said no more.

The nun on the other side hesitated again and again, but at last she could not help looking at Agatha with worry: "Your body, in the end…"

"It is alright," Agatha said softly, shaking her head. "Something happened. This shell of a body is just damaged."

Chapter 436: After the Disaster Ended

Snow fell in drifting flakes. It was not very heavy, but it looked as if it would last a long time. The Sun’s radiance was blocked by the dark clouds. The daylight that filtered through was not very bright, but it was undeniably there.

Through the street-facing window, they could see people already walking on the road, survivors of the disaster with fear still lingering in their eyes.

These still-shaken citizens emerged from their hiding places. On the streets they checked that the people they knew were still alive, or asked after the missing. Some asked whether there was any new word from the Upper City. Others were still trapped in the terror of the mirror world incursion, shrinking away in fear from every figure that passed in front of them. They hurried out of their homes, then just as quickly locked themselves back inside.

Scarred Steam Walkers and equally battered city Guard Corps, Constable units, and Guardian squads passed the intersection. Their presence let many people finally relax a little. The loudspeakers mounted on the Steam Walkers broadcast a notice that the Visions had ended, that the mirror world incursion had receded. The whole city would now enter forty-eight hours of security control. During this time, the city’s authority would reassert control over the situation and clear hidden dangers throughout the city. Supplies,

electricity, steam power, and fresh water would be restored as quickly as possible, and every district was ordered to report casualties without delay…

The loudspeaker broadcast, full of static, grew more distant. Its crude sound quality only made the streets feel colder on this snowy day. Even so, after the Steam Walkers rumbled past, many people's nerves really did start to ease, little by little.

Shirley leaned over the living-room window, watching the scene on the street while she muttered: "I wonder how long the chaos will last… Bread is definitely going to get more expensive."

Nina sat on the sofa beside her, mouth open as she exhaled heat so intense it made the air ripple. She turned her head when she heard Shirley's grumbling: "It'll definitely be messy for a while. Back when Pland was restoring order it took three days… though it won't get too bad this time. The Constable units are still here, after all…"

"Hey, hey! Don't talk while facing me!" Shirley could hardly stay on her feet in the blast of hot air. She stumbled back from the window, dodging as she shouted at Nina: "Your breath is like a leaking steam core right now! Why is it so hot?!"

Nina quickly clapped a hand over her mouth. Hot air still streamed from the corners of her lips as she mumbled an apology: "Sorry, sorry… I stayed in that state for too long earlier…"

Just then, Duncan's voice reached the two girls' ears: "I told you, Nina can only stay in the sky for a short while right now. Her condition is still unstable."

As soon as Shirley heard his voice, she hurried to turn around and stand at attention. Nina also jumped down from the sofa and ran toward Duncan with a smile: "Uncle Duncan!"

Duncan smiled as well and gave Nina, who was still radiating heat all over, a gentle hug. Then he turned his head and nodded in reply to Morris and Vanna, who were rising from the nearby chairs and bowing to him. “Looks like you’re all in good shape.”

“In good condition,” Morris said, adjusting his blessed monocle. “And deeply shaken.”

“I thought that after the great fire in Pland my nerves were already thick enough,” Vanna added, her tone full of emotion and awe. “To be honest, talking with you like this is still more relaxing. I mean, at a normal ‘scale’.”

“Having it happen once in a while is more than enough,” Duncan waved a hand. “Though I have to admit, the view from the sky is impressive.”

As he spoke, his gaze fell on something lying on the dining table not far away.

It was a large book with a black cover. There were no words or symbols on the front. The whole book gave off a strange, dangerous feeling.

“Is this the ‘The Blasphemous Tome’ you took from that small Cult of Annihilation leader?” Duncan’s eyes rested on the book. “It really doesn’t look like anything respectable to read.”

“Yes.” Morris nodded and stepped forward to pick the book up with care. “Later, under safe conditions, I did some basic testing on it. My guess is that this isn’t an ‘original’, but a copy held by a special member of the Cult of Annihilation. If it were the original, it should have far greater power and be much more valuable. It wouldn’t have been carried into the city so casually by a minor leader.”

He paused, a note of uncertainty in his voice. “As for what this book is for… it might be used to spread doctrine, or serve as a medium in spells or rituals. It records some things related to the Abyssal Lord. That part should

serve as a source of power for those cultists, but the details are only guesswork."

As he spoke, he held the book out. "Would you like to look at it now?"

"I'll take it back to the ship and read it there," Duncan shook his head. "The city is still chaotic. Who knows what might happen if I open this book now. Better not add to the mess. And besides, we'll have a guest in a while."

"A guest?" Vanna asked curiously from the side. "Who would pay a visit at a time like this?"

Duncan glanced at Vanna, amusement in his tone. "A colleague of yours. She's on her way here."

After he finished, he paid no attention to the odd look that suddenly crossed Vanna's face. He simply walked over to the street-facing window, sat down on the sofa, and settled in as if to wait calmly.

Footsteps sounded beside him. Alice walked over to stand in front of Duncan, the doll's face wearing its usual optimistic, empty expression. "Captain! When are we going home? Are we going back after we see the guest?"

Duncan lifted his eyelids and looked at the doll with the hollow head. "You think… things here are already over?"

"Huh? Aren't they?" Alice looked completely puzzled. "The villains are all dead, the disaster is over, and then the people who are left go off to keep adventuring. At least that's what all the picture books say…"

The corner of Duncan's mouth twitched. He looked up at Alice. "What else do the picture books say?"

"They also say the prince and the knight lived happily ever after…"

Duncan: "…?"

He choked for a long moment before he finally managed to speak. “Usually, in those kinds of picture-book stories, there’s supposed to be a princess or something…”

“The princess ran off with the butler…”

Duncan stayed silent for a few seconds and drew in a slow breath.

“Where did you even get picture books like that?”

Alice thought for a moment, then lifted a hand and pointed at Shirley. “She has a lot of them in her room…”

The next second, before Duncan could say a word, Shirley shot to her feet and bolted for the door. “I just saw a used bookstore going out of business, they were clearing stock and the books were really cheap so I bought a whole pile, you were the one who told me to read more and that picture books were a good place to start, I didn’t know they were all that weird, no wonder the shop went under, none of this is my fault…”

The young lady raced across half the living room wailing like a ghost. Duncan had not even decided how he meant to lecture her when she already reached the door, yanked it open with a bang, and lifted a leg to run out.

The very next second, a thud came from outside the door, followed by Shirley’s startled shout: “What the heck did I just run into…”

Almost everyone in the room was dumbfounded. Alice had not reacted at all to what was happening. Nina had been startled by Shirley’s wailing at such close range. Vanna had never imagined Shirley would be that bold. As for Morris… the venerable old gentleman was still reeling from the story about the princess running off with the butler.

Only Duncan still sat calmly on the sofa. He did not chase after Shirley, and he was not even curious about the noise at the door.

He simply turned his head and looked toward the entrance.

Footsteps sounded, and a young lady walked in hesitantly.

She wore a black priest's robe marked with the sigil of the Church. Her eyes were covered by a thick black cloth. Her long hair hung loose down her back. On the exposed skin of her arms and neck, there were still crack-like scars. Wounds that should have been horrific instead carried a kind of sacred air, like stigmata.

More importantly, she was holding Shirley in one hand, dangling the girl as Shirley flailed and kicked.

"Sorry," Agatha lifted her head, a little nervous as she "looked" at the figures in the room. "I meant to knock, but… she suddenly rushed out."

As she spoke, her gaze swept the room.

In the house that had lost all color and turned into shades of black, white, and gray, one figure after another with a powerful presence entered her sight.

She saw the dim outline of an old man. Streams of colored light flowed around him, and matrix-like points of light flickered inside his body. It was as if Rahm had cast his divine gaze upon the mortal world.

Beside the old man stood a tall figure. Inside its outline, everything was dark and chaotic, filled with ominous lights and shadows that made one think of Subspace. Yet a wisp of ghostly green flame leaped among those shadows, holding the figure together.

A bright arc of flame stood near the window. The fire seemed to have no occult properties, but it released pure light and heat. Just gazing at it made her feel as if her very soul were being scorched.

There was also a hollow shell of a body standing in the room. Countless faint threads spread out from it. It seemed to be turning a curious gaze in this direction. Under that gaze, Agatha even felt a fear that her soul would be caught and turned into one of those thin threads.

And among these figures was the strongest of all.

A field of dazzling starlight rose and walked toward her.

“Welcome. I have been waiting for you for a long time.”

The starlight spoke to her.

Chapter 437: Devastation Everywhere

That field of dazzling starlight was speaking to her and walking toward her. It had been sitting on the sofa a moment ago, yet when it took a step in this direction, Agatha felt as if she were gazing at a giant beyond words. For a brief instant she even lost the ability to judge size and proportion. Her confused senses could no longer grasp how big this house was, and the giant formed by that starlight almost made her soul feel like it was suffocating.

But it was only a fleeting illusion. In the next moment, Agatha snapped out of her shock. She realized that her mind had not been affected by any presence in this room at all. It was as if she had already blended into this place naturally.

“I…” She steadied herself and gazed at the giant of starlight in front of her. She knew she was continuously gazing at the true form of an unspeakable being. Under normal circumstances, that would be no different from suicide. But once she confirmed that she really was not affected anymore, her courage grew. “I didn’t expect you would actually still be here. I only came to try my luck…”

“Where do you think I’d go? Walk off with a swagger while everything here is a mess? Like the heroes in the picture books who leave as soon as they finish their quest?” Duncan laughed as he turned his body a little, gesturing

for Agatha to come in. Then he paused, glanced at Alice from the corner of his eye, and added, “I mean the picture books with normal stories.”

Agatha blanked for a moment. She felt she could not quite keep up with this great being’s train of thought. But she quickly comforted herself with the idea that it was normal for mortals not to understand how Elder Gods thought, and stepped further into the room.

Duncan suddenly stopped and glanced at Agatha’s hand.

“…Could you put Shirley down first?” he said in a slightly odd tone. “And you too, Shirley, why do you look like you’re enjoying this?”

“Ah, sorry!” Agatha finally snapped back to herself and hurried to set the skinny girl she was holding down on the floor. But the instant she did, her expression suddenly changed.

Things had been chaotic at the door just now, and she had not focused on Shirley. Only now did she suddenly notice the anomaly on the girl, limbs warped by a symbiotic pact with Abyssal demons, chains extending out from within her body and hidden away, and the Abyssal Hound crouching in the shadows, sneaking glances at the outside world.

“Abyssal Deep…” Agatha spoke without thinking, every muscle in her body tensing at once.

But before she could do anything, Duncan’s voice came from the side. “Relax. It’s just a harmless hound. I sometimes need a hound to help me find things.”

“A harmless… hound?” Agatha said, her expression strange, as her gaze swept the room again on instinct.

Those figures came into view again, one that looked like a chosen of the gods, another that seemed to carry a divine blessing from Subspace, one

that apparently housed the power of the Sun, and even a shell of a soul she could not see through at all…

Her gaze fell once more on the girl called Shirley.

The Abyssal Hound, realizing it had been noticed, was crouching in the shadows with its neck hunched, looking utterly pitiful.

Agatha fell silent.

An Elder God and His followers were gathered here. Indeed, any Abyssal demon in this place could be called harmless to humans and animals.

“Don’t worry, Shirley is not an Annihilator,” Duncan said when he saw her fall silent, explaining patiently. “She met Dog for other reasons, and both of them now act under my orders. They won’t harm the city.”

As he spoke, he pointed to a chair not far away. “Sit. You must have a lot to say.”

Agatha walked over slowly, and Duncan watched how she moved. She found the chair’s position with precision, but when she sat down there was still a hint of hesitation and groping.

“It seems you still need some time to get used to your current state,” Duncan said. “Is that going to be a problem?”

This mysterious being still sounded unfailingly warm and gentle. Agatha shifted a little, feeling uneasy. “…I really am not used to the way I perceive the world now, but there is no need to worry about this body. In fact, the changes that happened to me have quite a few benefits. I can see many things I could not observe before. I just… need to adapt.”

“I’m sorry,” Duncan said, his tone quite serious. “I didn’t expect it to cause this kind of change. In fact, you didn’t have to use such an extreme method as a self-sacrificial rite.”

“But it was the most efficient way,” Agatha shook her head lightly. “Nothing is more suitable than a Gatekeeper as the bearer of your great power.”

Duncan did not press the point. After that, his attention shifted to her current outfit.

“You look very different from the last time we met,” he remarked. “It seems… you look more like a priest now than before.”

“I am temporarily acting as archbishop,” Agatha nodded slightly. “Archbishop Ivan is gone. Now that the fighting in the city is over, what we need more than a fully armed Gatekeeper is someone to lead the Church in comforting the souls of the dead and the minds of the living.”

“Archbishop Ivan…” Duncan’s tone grew more solemn. After a brief silence, he sighed softly. “I never met him, but at that time I sensed the protection that descended over the city-state. It was short, but his efforts did weaken the link between the mirror world and the Mortal Realm for a while. Without him, many more people would have died.”

“May he know peace in Bartok’s realm,” Agatha said softly. “He… held on for many years. Now he can finally rest for a long time.”

“He will,” Duncan said casually. “Though I don’t really understand what Bartok’s domain is like, as one of the True Gods He should treat those noble souls fairly.” He then changed the subject. “Now, tell me how things are in the city.”

Agatha nodded lightly.

She knew that as the Gatekeeper of the Church of Death, and as one of the few people left who could still keep order in the city, she should not casually reveal Frostholm’s current plight to others. She especially should not deepen her dealings with a being whose true nature was unknown and

who was suspected to be an Elder God. But after she saw that colossal figure standing in the waters off the city, and after she carried out that self-sacrificial rite, she understood. Whether for Frostholm or for herself, they had already formed a bond with this mysterious being that would be hard to sever.

Now that this being clearly still had an interest in watching over this battered city-state, she had no way to avoid the matter.

If the choice she made today turned out to be a sin, then she would let the Church and her god judge her.

“Frostholm’s current situation… is very bad,” she began in a low voice. “As you know, we just lost Archbishop Ivan. The Church’s priests and Guardians also took heavy losses while defending the city-state. Now fear and tension hang over the city, along with all the negative effects brought by so many deaths and injuries. If these things are not handled in time, secondary disasters are very likely. Horrors will grow out of people’s hearts. With the Church short on manpower, ‘fear’ itself will snowball throughout the city-state.

“In fact, sunset a few hours from now is very likely to be the start of the real test. During the earlier mirror world incursion, Frostholm went a very long time without the light of the Sun. That greatly weakened the city-state’s protection against extraordinary powers. On the first night that follows, no one knows what will happen.

“On the other hand, City Hall is in even worse shape than the Church. Besides the casualties suffered by the city-state’s Guard Corps and Constable units, the most serious problem is…”

Agatha clearly hesitated when she got this far. But after a few seconds of struggle she still laid out the situation. After all, the governor’s disappearance was not something that could be hidden from anyone.

“The most serious problem is that the governor is missing.”

Duncan raised his eyebrows. “Missing?”

“He disappeared in the Boiling Gold mine. And I…” Agatha stumbled over her words, as if she were still trying to arrange them. After a few seconds she went on, her expression complicated. “Another me once led a team to investigate the tunnel where the governor vanished. According to the exploration party that later returned to the Great Cathedral, ‘I’ and Governor Winston both entered an anomalous area sealed off by stone walls, and neither of us came back…”

Her voice was low and hesitant. It was obvious that when she spoke of that other self, her mood was far less calm than she pretended.

Duncan could almost picture how tangled, confused, and conflicted she had been when she returned to the Great Cathedral and asked the other priests about what that other her had been doing in the past few days.

He gazed at Agatha calmly. “You can put it more directly. The governor of Frostholm is already dead. That is your judgment, isn’t it?”

“Yes.” Agatha finally stopped hesitating and spoke plainly. “There is no evidence, but I really ‘know’ that he is dead. He died in some strange, dark space. We probably won’t even be able to recover the body.”

“You ‘know’,” Duncan repeated, putting weight on the word. Then he shifted his posture in the chair. “It seems you’ll be going back to the Boiling Gold mine again.”

“That was… where ‘she’ vanished for the last time,” Agatha nodded gently. “When she disappeared, I sensed something I can’t put into words. It was as if I could feel her thoughts. I think… she had many things she wanted to tell me, but she ran out of time…”

Agatha stopped, then went on. “And… the members of the exploration team who returned from the mine told me about something else. It was something that the other me had told them while she was leading them in the mine. That is what unsettles me even more…”

Chapter 438: Getting to Know Each Other Again

Agatha did not hold anything back. In front of this benevolent being who had already saved Frostholm from the brink of destruction, she laid out all the information she currently had.

One part of the intel came from her own observations and conclusions during the mirror world Frostholm operation. The other part she had pried out bit by bit after she returned to the great Cathedral, from various priests and from her own trusted aide. All of it had happened while she was trapped in that mirror world city.

They were things that the “other her” had experienced.

The Boiling Gold mine that Frostholm relied on for survival hid a huge secret. The so?called Boiling Gold ore had already run dry back in the days of the Frostholm Queen. The governors of each generation might be holding an enormous secret. Governor Winston and the “other Agatha” had vanished together deep in the mine, and before they disappeared, that “other Agatha” seemed to have discovered some shocking truth. The intense surge of her will had even reached the real Agatha on this side…

Duncan listened in silence, only now and then asking about some point of detail. He waited until Agatha finished everything before he finally let out a quiet sigh.

“You just told me Frostholm’s biggest secret—at a time like this, you’re not worried I might be a being with bad intentions?”

“After seeing the methods you used to destroy that mirror world city, I decided there was no point in guessing at your intentions anymore,” Agatha said calmly. “If you really meant this city harm, all of us would be dead before the Sun went down.”

“…Is this how all you protectors of city-states give compliments, so unique?” Duncan muttered, then quietly glanced at Vanna beside him.

Vanna instantly turned her gaze away and pretended she had not heard anything.

The old scholar Morris, sitting across the table, could not help leaning forward. After hearing the shocking fact that the Boiling Gold vein had already dried up long ago, his curiosity had clearly swelled to the point of bursting: “So what is the situation in the Boiling Gold mine now? Can you still find raw ore? The stuff you have been digging out all these years… was it really Boiling Gold?”

“The mine is still sealed,” Agatha answered frankly. “After the mirror world incursion faded, there were loud crashes and tremors from the shafts. For safety, and because we are short of people, we still have not confirmed the situation inside. But according to reports from the transit station and the smelter at the mine… at least the Boiling Gold that was brought out earlier has all stayed the same.”

“The mirror world city has been destroyed… but the Boiling Gold, which in theory counts as an ‘Anomaly product’, did not vanish? Now that is interesting…” Morris rubbed his chin without thinking. “You know, the replicas and monsters in the city all turned into piles of sludge the instant the mirror world city collapsed… so all that Boiling Gold was real? How does that work? Can the Sacred Abyssal Lord really create true Boiling Gold?”

“This is not the time for academic research,” Vanna could not help grumbling, then turned her head to Agatha. “So when are you planning to go down and confirm what is happening in the mine?”

Agatha hesitated, then spoke, not very sure: “I think… at least after order in the city has roughly stabilized, after the tremors and crashes in the shafts have stopped. And… at the very least, we have to get safely through the first night after the disaster.”

As she spoke, she lifted her head and, almost without thinking, glanced out the window.

Snow was still falling. It was still daytime, but behind the clouds the Sun was slowly sinking. That hazy ball of light was about to brush the tip of the far-off Cathedral spire.

“In two hours, the Sun will set. That will be the first test we face after the disaster…”

“Sorry, let me cut in,” Vanna suddenly raised a hand, breaking off Agatha’s worried sigh. “I think… you actually do not have to worry about the veil of night descending. Compared to all the other troubles you are facing, ‘night’ might become the last thing this city-state needs to fear from now on.”

Agatha froze for a moment: “Why do you say that?”

“…Experience,” Vanna said. She then glanced back at Duncan, and only after seeing him give her a small nod did she turn back to Agatha and go on: “Pland’s experience.”

“Pland…” Agatha was confused for a second, but the next moment she suddenly remembered the reports she had received before, the messages that had come from far away—about the large-scale Visions that had struck Pland, the crisis of the Black Sun, the history rebuilt in flame, and…

…a “rumor” that had spread from Pland through all kinds of channels.

About that chilling ghost captain, a moving calamity on the Boundless Sea, the terrifying Subspace Shadows—about Duncan Abnomar, who had already regained his humanity.

The expression on the young Gatekeeper, who was also the acting Archbishop, instantly became very interesting. She stood up so quickly that her chair gave a loud creak.

All the suspicious clues suddenly found their answers. All her uneasy guesses were abruptly confirmed. The scattered, messy pieces of information were strung together.

“I admit, this is a bit awkward,” Duncan said with a shrug, his tone a little helpless.

Agatha still stood there stiffly, staring at Duncan without moving. No one could see her “eyes” just then, but the expression of this Miss Gatekeeper was clearly more than simple embarrassment.

After a long time, she finally broke the silence: “No wonder… your followers call you ‘Captain’… I should have thought of it earlier. On the Boundless Sea, what other ‘captain’ could be as special as you?”

“About the Viseran Thirteen Isles, I am very sorry,” Duncan said. “I have no memory of it at all, but the evidence seems solid.”

As he spoke, Duncan tried his best to make his voice sound warm and reliable. But considering his fearsome “reputation”, and the display of power he had shown in front of Frostholm just a few hours ago, that bit of gentleness in his tone clearly did not help much. Anyone could see that Agatha had stayed tense ever since.

Only after quite a while did Agatha herself break that stiff, awkward state: “I… well, I will be honest. Ever since the day I advanced to Saint, the Church has kept stressing to us that once we found any trace of ‘Subspace

Shadows Captain Duncan', we must report to the highest Death Sanctuary at once—its priority was above all natural Calamities, on the same level as a Subspace incursion. I do not know if you can understand what that means."

"Oh, I understand," Duncan was about to answer, but Vanna spoke up first instead, casually chatting with the colleague in front of her: "We get reminders about that every year on our side too, and we even have special disaster-response plans for it, though we never actually used them."

Duncan gave Vanna a strange look: "You are saying this right in front of me?"

Only then did Vanna suddenly realize it and quickly straighten her face: "Ah, sorry, Captain…"

Agatha was a little slow to catch up, or maybe Duncan's presence had simply shocked her too much. Only now did she suddenly focus on the tall lady in front of her: "Wait, so you are…"

"Inquisitor of the city-state of Pland… in a sense, we are colleagues," Vanna said, looking a bit embarrassed. "Sorry, I did not mean to hide it."

One wave of information after another pounded her mind. Agatha felt almost dazed. Only now did she realize that the end of a disaster really was only a beginning—and the complicated situation after the disaster was pressing toward her from a direction she had never imagined.

She hesitated, then sat back down in her chair, and looked at Vanna with a hard-to-read expression: "But why are you with Captain Duncan? You should be one of the highest representatives of the Deep Sea Church in Pland… does Pland not need an Inquisitor anymore?"

"This is exactly the Church's arrangement. The details are not convenient to explain for now. I can only say… this matter cannot be made public yet. If

your status did not meet the need-to-know level, I would not be telling you even this," Vanna said seriously, then paused for a moment. "As for Pland… yes, as you said, right now it does not need an Inquisitor, at least not the old kind of Inquisitor-and-Guardian system."

Agatha could not help rubbing her forehead. Other reports that had come from afar recently, reports she had not yet had time to verify, rose in her mind. She spoke hesitantly: "So… just as the intel said, Pland really has peaceful, quiet nights now?"

Vanna looked a bit surprised: "The news has already reached Frostholm?"

"We are only remote, not cut off," Agatha said, and then could not help pressing on. "Please tell me, has Pland truly stopped fearing the dark?"

"…At least so far, the nights in Pland are even safer than the days in many city-states. My uncle is even thinking about opening a kind of evening market to fit the city's recent changes, though that still needs careful discussion and testing," Vanna nodded. "Since you already know about that, I imagine you have heard the other piece of news too—after the Black Sun incident ended, Pland gained a new identity."

"Vision-Pland, the first Vision in history without a number," Agatha said without thinking. Her gaze could not help drifting to Duncan. Now she finally understood what Vanna's earlier words had meant. "So… Frostholm will now undergo the same change?"

Feeling that invisible yet very real "gaze", Duncan only smiled and nodded: "Maybe."

Chapter 439: The Captain’s Suggestion

Duncan shifted into a more comfortable position and leaned back against the sofa. His gaze, peeking through the gaps between the bandages crisscrossing his face, rested on the Goddess official in front of him with a half-smile.

“Now that you know who I am, how do you feel?” He smiled as he spoke. “From the point of view of the Church of Death—you should report this at once.”

Agatha opened her mouth but could not say anything for quite a while. After a full half minute, she finally gave a bitter little smile and spread her hands: “You have put me in a very awkward position…”

“But you really should report everything that happened here to the Church at once,” Duncan put away his smile, and his tone finally turned serious. “Pland was the first, Frostholm is the second. Those cultists have indeed caused a lot of trouble over the years, but never so many big incidents so close together. And do not forget, besides two city-states coming close to total destruction, the Sun above our heads—Vision 001—has also shown some unsettling changes lately.”

Agatha threw off her embarrassment at once. With Duncan’s reminder, her expression slowly grew solemn: “…You mean these events are all connected?”

“I do not know—do not look so surprised, I am not some all-knowing being,” Duncan said casually. “But I have a habit. When all kinds of low-probability events happen one after another, I tend to think of them as ‘omens’ of a larger system starting to go wrong. What the cultists did in the two city-states may not look connected, but have you thought about why they all managed to succeed lately? In all of history there have been so many large-scale heretic sacrificial rites. How many actually stirred up anything on this level?”

Agatha fell into thought, and her expression grew heavier.

“Report it all,” Duncan said softly. “Do not let any clue slip by—let the minds of clever people really think it over.”

“I understand. I will make a full report,” Agatha said with great seriousness, then fixed her gaze on Duncan and added on purpose: “Everything.”

“I look forward to the Church of Death’s reaction,” Duncan breathed out gently, as if putting down a weight. “It is not good to keep dragging this out.”

After that, the sitting room fell quiet for a while. It seemed everyone had sunk into their own thoughts (Alice excepted). No one knew how long had passed before Agatha suddenly spoke and broke the silence: “I should go back.”

“Not stay a bit longer?” Duncan asked. “In the current situation, the moment you go out, you will have countless things to give you a headache. You will not get many chances to hide here for some peace and quiet.”

“That is exactly why I have to go back as soon as possible,” Agatha shook her head. “The city-state has countless problems that need solving. It is not just the Church; City Hall is also a complete mess. If I keep hiding for some quiet, then truly there will be no one left to hold the situation together.”

“A complete mess…” Duncan repeated thoughtfully, then suddenly asked a question. “Do you think, relying only on Frostholm’s remaining organization and manpower, you can really restore order to the whole city in a short time?”

Agatha paused, not understanding why Duncan had suddenly asked this. After a brief silence, she still nodded: “…I will do my best.”

“‘Do your best’—but many times, doing your best does not solve the problem.”

“…What do you mean?”

“I just suddenly had a very bold suggestion,” Duncan said with a smile, his gaze settling on Agatha. “A suggestion from an outsider.”

…

When Agatha left No. 44 Oak Street, the daylight had already grown dim. The power of the Sun was slowly fading from the Mortal Realm, while the fine snow still flew in the sky. The tiny drifting flakes fell out of the dark chaos above, passed through the dim halos cast by gas streetlamps, and slowly covered the cold, empty streets.

A Guardian night patrol unit marched past the distant intersection. Now and then the clanking footsteps of a Steam Walker broke the silence on the road. The chimes that marked the change of day and night floated from far away, and in the evening wind came the organ music of the little Cathedral at the street corner.

The scarred city-state was licking its wounds beneath the veil of night.

The cold wind swept through the alleys, tugging at Agatha’s hair and skirt. Standing on the snowy street, she held out her hand and tilted her head slightly: “It is still snowing.”

Vanna, who had walked her to the door, turned her gaze curiously: “You cannot see the snowflakes?”

“I cannot—but I can feel them,” Agatha said softly. “There are many more things in my field of vision now, but there are also many things gone. It will take a long time to get used to it.”

She slowly drew back her hand, and a small smile suddenly appeared on her face. “But the good news is, I no longer feel how sharp the cold wind is. No matter how many layers of clothing I put on or how many stoves I lit, this world… always felt just as cold.”

“…Sorry, it is hard for me to imagine that feeling.”

“Oh, do not worry about it. It actually does not trouble me much,” Agatha said with a small laugh. She slowly curled her fingers into a fist, and as power gathered, faint ghostly green flame rose along the crisscrossing “scars” all over her body. The flame flowed through her like blood. “Like this, it feels a bit better.”

Vanna was silent for a few seconds: “If the Captain knew you were using the flame he gave you as a hand warmer, his expression would probably be quite something.”

“What kind of person is he?” Agatha let the Power of Flame fade and suddenly asked with great curiosity. “Is he very strict or scary in daily life?”

“What do you think? You have already met him twice,” Vanna said.

“I feel that every report about him is off from the truth. He is far calmer and friendlier than I imagined. But… maybe I should call him ‘He’ instead. I do not know if I should judge a being like Him by mortal standards. I know He used to be human, but Subspace… you know what I mean.”

Vanna thought for a few seconds and gently shook her head: “I have not followed him for very long, so I probably cannot give you a clear answer.

But I can tell you that I once had worries like yours. And in the end, the Storm Cathedral decided to send me, an Inquisitor, aboard the Vanished. Just as Captain Duncan chose to believe that a ‘replica’ could have humanity, we also believe—or rather, choose to believe—in Captain Duncan’s humanity. After all…”

She suddenly stopped, lifted her head, and looked up at the sky where the snowflakes were swirling. After a moment, she spoke softly as if to herself: “After all, this world is too cold. If even we stop believing in hope, then on this Boundless Sea there would really be nothing left but a bitter wind.”

Agatha did not speak for a while.

After a few seconds of quiet, Vanna suddenly asked: “What do you think of the Captain’s suggestion?”

Agatha fell into thought. After a while she answered with a complicated expression: “Letting the Sea Mist Fleet enter the city… To be honest, I do not even know whether that will restore order to the city-state or bring greater chaos. You have been living in this city for a while. You must know very well what the Sea Mist Fleet means to most people in Frostholm…”

“To most people in Pland, the Vanished is just as terrifying,” Vanna said. “But believe me, after a terrible disaster, people’s ‘ability to accept things’ really reaches a shocking level. From the point of view of the crowd, their longing for a stable life will outweigh many worries.”

“A longing for a stable life…”

Agatha spoke softly. Through this body that had already lost its life, she felt the cold of the snowy night, and for some reason, she thought of something else.

Fifty years ago, when that great uprising broke out, it had also been snowing.

“I will discuss this matter carefully with the officials at City Hall,” she said, as if making up her mind. She turned to Vanna. “And from a personal point of view, I will support it.”

“We all hope everything will turn out well,” Vanna said.

“Yes, we all hope everything will turn out well.”

Agatha repeated the words, then waved her hand and walked toward the Steam Car parked at the curb, the one bearing the Church’s crest.

But after only a few steps, she suddenly stopped.

“Is there something else?” Vanna asked curiously.

“Some… private questions. I hope I am not being too rude,” Agatha turned her head back. Her expression looked a little strange as she asked hesitantly: “Did you really once leap off a cliff, slay a spawn, and then come back safe and sound?”

Vanna froze, her eyes going odd: “Why suddenly ask that?”

“I do not know either. The question just suddenly popped into my head,” Agatha said, looking a bit embarrassed. “I feel like I heard that kind of rumor somewhere before… Sorry if it makes you uncomfortable, I…”

“It is nothing. It did happen,” Vanna relaxed and waved her hand with a smile. “But the truth is not like the rumor at all. I actually stepped wrong while taking a walk and fell from the edge of a cliff. When I hit the ground, I happened to crush a Deep Sea corruption body that had somehow washed ashore. It was not a real ‘spawn’, and it was hardly any kind of heroic kill. I have no idea why it spread that way.”

Agatha’s mouth opened slightly—in spite of the cloth over her eyes, her expression still clearly said she was stunned.

“Then… you were all right?” the Miss Gatekeeper asked without thinking.

“I was actually hurt pretty badly,” Vanna said with an embarrassed smile. Then she patted her chest and struck a strong pose. “But luckily I am an athlete. I went home, drank hot water, and lay in bed for two days, and I was fine.”

Agatha: “…?”

The Miss Gatekeeper was deeply shaken.

Vanna looked a bit puzzled: “Why are you looking at me like that?”

“…You Pland athletes are terrifying,” Agatha said.

Chapter 440: Sea Mist and Frostholm

The night was deep. The light, fluttering snow had kept falling into the second half of the night and still had not stopped. The snow was not heavy, yet it still laid a soft, silent cover over the whole city. The not-too-thick layer of snow was like pale bandages, wrapping the many scars the city had earned in the disaster and hiding all the wounds that had not yet had time to heal.

Broken buildings, bloodstains no one had had time to clean, scrapped Steam Walkers, barricades waiting to be torn down, and the dried “mud” that clogged almost every corner of the city and would take who knew how long to clear away.

The mirror world invasion had faded, but the “by-products” brought by this Visions disaster remained in the city as solid matter.

The Church had already, according to procedure, taken over the running of the city after nightfall.

Guardians carrying consecrated lanterns kept their gaze on the streets under the veil of night. They watched every shadowy corner that the gas streetlamps could not fully light, and they stayed wary of any strange sound that reached their ears.

The air held the drifting scent of burning incense. The soft, murmured benedictions of Nightwatch priests carried a calming strength.

“Tonight seems very quiet…” A black-clad Guard stared at the dark patches along the street. After a long time, he suddenly muttered to the comrade beside him: “I thought there would still be fierce fighting tonight.”

“Everyone thought that,” another Guard spoke softly. She was a woman with long hair falling over her shoulders. Several strips of cloth, covered in Prayer text, were sealed with wax onto the consecrated lantern at her waist, marking her as the leader of this squad. “After such a serious supernatural disaster, and with so many priests sacrificed… in theory, the city’s defenses should be at their lowest point tonight.”

“The other Nightwatch squads don’t seem to have reported anything. There hasn’t even been a single whistle in the whole night.”

“In any case, keep your nerves tight. Before the Sun rises, we cannot relax for even a moment.”

“Yes, Captain.”

The woman called captain gave a small nod, then looked toward another squad working not far away.

A delicate Brass Censer hung from a thin chain, sending out curls of faint smoke. A silent Monk used the incense to give divine blessing to the street, murmuring prayers to the God of Death. A few low-ranking priests with him carefully scraped samples of the black sludge from nearby walls, lampposts, and the ground, then sealed them into glass bottles.

Once dried, that “mud” had lost all activity. It no longer twisted into terrifying shapes. When the scraper cut through its surface, its texture was like some half-dry, fine-grained… “paint.”

“How much of this ‘sludge’ do you think there is in the city now?”

She could not help turning her head to mutter to the subordinate beside her.

“Who knows? I heard what we see on the surface is still the small part. The sewers and the subway are the worst, and there are several wastewater treatment plants that are almost packed full of this stuff. City Hall is a mess right now. No one knows how long it will take to clear it all.”

“Cleaning sludge… at least that’s the easiest trouble we have to face,” the female captain sighed lightly and lifted her head to look toward the end of the street. “The trouble Frostholm faces now is not just this strange mud.”

The black-clad Guard next to her also raised his head without thinking and looked in the direction his captain’s gaze had gone.

That was the Harbor district at the edge of the city-state. Lights blazed there, and faint sounds drifted over.

“Yeah, it’s not just the mud…” the black-clad Guard muttered, his tone odd and a bit tense. “A whole Sea Mist Fleet is still surrounding this city.”

…

In the eastern Harbor district, the lights were bright and the noise of people filled the air.

As the only harbor that had held off the Monster invasion through the whole defense and stayed in operation, the East Harbor was still busy even after the battle ended.

All docks and engineering machines were in use. Every worker who still had any strength had to work overtime. Several piers that had taken minor damage in the daytime battle had already received quick temporary repairs so that ships in better shape could dock and rest there.

For many people in the city, the battle was over. Tonight was their time to recover their spirits and heal their wounds. But for the Frostholm navy and the Harbor logistics units, the battle still went on. Many ships were badly

damaged and needed repair. Many wounded still needed treatment. And beyond all that, they faced a problem even more tricky and more complex:

The Sea Mist Fleet, their temporary comrades for the day, and their deep nightmare of the last fifty years.

That largest, strongest “ghost ship,” the one people in Frostholm had used for fifty years to scare naughty children, was now moored beside the biggest pier in the East Harbor.

Its towering bow rose into the veil of night. The gun emplacements and bridge on its deck formed ghostly silhouettes in the wind and snow. Light from the shore fell on the armor belt and reflected back a pale glare that brought to mind bare bone. On the steel giant’s side, along the rail facing Frostholm, a wide banner flapped in the wind. Rough letters were painted on it, clearly scribbled in as a last-minute idea:

“Sea Mist Venture Capital Company, temporary survey and visit ship stationed at Frostholm.”

Even the most battle-hardened Frostholm soldiers had never seen anything like this. Anyone walking past the pier at this moment would have to stare at those rough letters for a long time, fighting the wild urge to slap themselves awake a few times.

“Captain,” First Mate Aiden crossed the deck and came up behind Tyrian, who was standing at the rail and looking down. “The banner is up, just like you said. We tried to make it look friendly.”

Tyrian gave a quiet grunt in reply, then raised his hand and pointed at the pier below. soldiers and workers sometimes stopped near the sea mist, standing there uneasily to watch the ship. Tyrian said: “But they still look pretty nervous to me.”

“I don’t know why. Maybe people in Frostholm these days just scare easier,” Aiden said as he rubbed his smooth, bald head. “Should I tell the men to go down and chase off the ones standing around and staring?”

“No need,” Tyrian thought for a moment and shook his head. “Father ordered us not to clash with the city-state again. At a tense time like this, we shouldn’t irritate these easily startled Frostholm folk.”

Aiden shrugged. “All right then, since it’s the old captain’s order.”

“How is everyone doing?” Tyrian suddenly asked after a short silence. “I mean the Second Generation sailors.”

“Well… after half a century, we’ve come back to this familiar place again,” Aiden sighed softly, speaking with feeling. “It’s impossible for the ship to be calm. Right now, almost every compartment is talking about docking here, and about dealing with the Frostholm navy again. Even the first-generation sailors have been affected and are talking with them.

“Some are looking forward to it. Some resist it. More of them are just lost, because no one ever imagined how this day would go. But… everyone will support your decision. They are waiting for your orders.”

For a while, Tyrian did not speak. In his mind, he seemed to see again the scene he had watched earlier from the bridge.

The Queen’s second order after half a century: “Protect Frostholm.”

Was that really true? Was that the power the Queen had left behind, or only a simple illusion?

It no longer seemed to matter.

The Queen had once ordered the Sea Mist Fleet to stay away from the main island of Frostholm. Now he had brought the fleet back here. Maybe… the Queen’s order back then had been for this very day.

“In any case, we came all this way,” Tyrian breathed out lightly. The air from his mouth and nose turned into white mist in the cold night. “The Commander here wants to host his ‘comrades.’ That is fine. I should go and greet them.”

“Want me to go with you?”

“Yes. And bring a few more people who know how to behave. Tell them in advance that this time, we are not here to fight.”

“All right,” Aiden nodded, then could not help asking one more question: “Uh… any other requirements for the people coming along?”

Tyrian thought about it. “Faces mostly in one piece. Limbs still attached to the torso. No ‘parts’ falling off while they walk. Use your own judgment. As long as their clothes can cover most of the holes, it will do.”

“Got it, Captain.”

…

In the Harbor defense office, Chief Commander Lister was checking his uniform and medals one last time.

He had seen big occasions before, but even as a well-trained career soldier, he still felt a bit uneasy about the “occasion” he was about to face.

It was not because it was too grand, but because it was something that had never happened before.

He was going to meet the leader of the Sea Mist Fleet. After fifty years of standoff and hatred, the fleet that had once “defected” from the city-state had come back.

Many parts of the city-state were still in chaos. The Governor’s disappearance had left City Hall in a blind panic. Even so, in the middle of all this disorder, he had still arranged this special reception.

Because he knew that today's Frostholm could not bear any further damage. No matter what the officials and advisers over at City Hall thought, he had to keep that fearsome ghost fleet calm. If there was ever going to be peace with that "Pirate Lord," then this moment was probably the only chance.

He fastened the last button and let out a slow breath.

Then he lowered his head and picked up a new breast badge from the desk. It showed his new rank of General. He calmly let his gaze trace every line carved into it.

"A battlefield promotion, huh… Well, someone has to step up."

He lifted his head and, facing the mirror, carefully fixed the badge to his uniform.

Chapter 441: Another Possibility

Tyrian walked into the meeting room.

There was no soft music for high society and no grand, luxurious ballroom. This was only a reception room under the Harbor Administration. The hosts were a few representatives from the navy. Tyrian even recognized a few faces.

He had dealt with them in recent years.

Lister rose to greet the “Pirate Lord” walking into the room.

“I am sorry. Our conditions are limited right now,” the Chief Commander said as he held out his hand, his tone carrying an apology. “In this rush, this is the best reception we could prepare.”

Tyrian did not take the offered hand at once. He first lifted his head and looked around the room. A few representatives in Frostholm navy uniforms stood behind Lister. Their faces were still fairly calm, but the other attendants were clearly not so relaxed. Some secretly watched the Undying who had come in with Tyrian. Others tried to act composed and turned their eyes away. Yet they all had two things in common: besides tension, there was a tiredness in their eyes that could not be hidden.

Tyrian smiled, then reached out and shook Lister’s hand.

“This is fine. If you had really set up a grand banquet for me at a time like this, and even found a few people to play fiddles in the corner, then there would be no point in us talking at all.”

Feeling the strength in the hand of this “iron Vice Admiral,” Lister’s expression twitched slightly. He pulled his hand back and said in a slightly awkward tone: “You do have some prejudice against us, but you also know the truth. We only stand on different sides. As soldiers, the Frostholm navy today will still defend our city-state as firmly as you once did.”

“Yes, I know. And I have already seen it with my own eyes. Otherwise, I would never have accepted your invitation, General,” Tyrian said with a small smile. His gaze swept across the badge on Lister’s chest, and he paused slightly on the word “General.” Then he shook his head, walked toward the center of the room, and spoke again: “Let’s end the small talk here. You and I both know what time it is. We can talk about this city, talk about the future or, if you have the courage, we can talk about my father.”

“Your father…” Lister sat down on the sofa. When he heard Tyrian’s last words, his body clearly stiffened. In the next second, the scene that all Frostholm people would remember for life rose again in his mind.

From the Boundless Sea came the reflection of giants. Two eyes like twin Suns opened in the clouds. The mirror world city-state, torn and peeled away from this one, burned into ash in the giants’ hands.

A shudder rose from the depths of his soul. Lister forced himself to stop the memory and looked at the Pirate Lord sitting across from him, still shaken.

“So that really was your father? That being who returned from Subspace…” He started speaking with a pause on every word. It felt as if simply talking about it, simply naming it, might draw some nameless gaze down on him. “At the last moment, it was really his hand that saved us… but that form of his has never appeared in any…”

“It will show up in the records from now on,” Tyrian said with a shrug. “Congratulations, General Lister. Frostholm will be the first city-state to witness and record this.”

He paused, then asked with real interest: “I’m curious. What is the mood in the city now, especially among people like you? How do you see what happened?”

“Tension and fear still fill the city. I must admit, this night has been very hard for everyone. The disaster is over, but it ended in a way most people cannot understand and that chills them to the bone. Many are guessing what the being that came down on the sea at the end really was, but I think… if they truly knew, the panic might be even worse,” Lister said, and he let out a sigh. “Even at City Hall, it was only after we sorted a great many records and clues that we dared to guess that it was your father. Don’t blame us for being slow. That scene was too shocking. Anyone would hesitate for a long time.”

“I can understand,” Tyrian sighed, his expression a bit strange. “He did not tell me in advance either. I was just as scared as you when it happened.”

Lister looked at the Pirate Lord in front of him. A strange feeling stirred in his heart. It was an uncontrollable curiosity mixed with the instinctive fear people felt when facing the unknown. He could not help imagining how this “son of Duncan” spoke to that terrifying father of his. How had father and son decided to help Frostholm? How did that shadow from Subspace view the world today?

“I would like to ask,” the General who had risen through a battlefield promotion finally could not hold back. “Your father… has he really, as the rumors say, found his humanity again?”

Tyrian looked genuinely surprised. “In what way does he not seem human?”

At once, Lister thought of the giant figure standing in the sky, and of the city-state burning to ash and being ground to dust in the giants’ hands. He opened his mouth, holding back a stomach full of rude words, but did not dare let even one of them out.

After a long struggle, the Frostholm General only forced out one stiff line: “I believe he does now have the heart of a human.”

Tyrian laughed. “And I believe that came straight from your heart.”

Then the Pirate Lord of the Frost Sea picked up a wine glass from the low table and solemnly raised it toward Lister. “Let us drink to this mutual trust.”

Lister: “…”

The Frostholm General raised his glass, clinked it against Tyrian’s with a stiff smile, took a small sip, and set it down. “Then may I ask what you and your father plan to do next?”

Tyrian looked completely at ease. “I don’t know.”

Lister’s eyes flew wide. “You don’t know?”

“He has not told me yet,” Tyrian spread his hands. There was a joy in his eyes that he could not hide. After matching wits with the Frostholm navy for half a century, it was this “friendly talk” that pleased him most. “I came here only because of Father’s order. When I joined the battle afterward, it was only to protect the city that Her Majesty Queen Ray Nora once protected. I never thought about what comes next. That depends on Father’s mood.”

Lister spoke without thinking: “Then how can we contact your father?”

Tyrian lifted his eyelids with a half-smile. “You really want to contact him? Then I can teach you a ritual…”

“That won’t be necessary,” Lister felt his back go cold at once and quickly waved his hand. “I was only speaking without thinking.”

“When you are talking about ‘him,’ it is better not to speak without thinking. You never know when ‘he’ might actually turn his gaze toward

you," Tyrian said. His expression then shifted in a subtle way, as if he had remembered something not very pleasant. He quickly shook his head, looked back at Lister, and changed to a lighter tone. "Relax, young man. I was only making a joke. You are all wound up too tight. This is the first time in fifty years that the Sea Mist Fleet has 'come home.' Shouldn't we have an easy mood, like a family reunion?"

Young man…

The corner of Lister's mouth twitched, but he quickly swallowed his awkwardness. His face grew serious. "General Tyrian, then I will be frank. To put it plainly… Frostholm is in trouble."

"I know. We just solved it."

"No, I am not talking about the Visions invasion. That invasion was not trouble. It was a disaster. Now the disaster is over, but the trouble that follows it will come one after another. Order in Frostholm is on the verge of collapse. Even if we make it through this night in peace, we still have to deal with public security, supplies, sea safety, and a whole pile of other problems…"

"And what does that have to do with me?" Tyrian leaned back on the sofa and calmly fixed his gaze on Lister's eyes. "I am a Rebel. I don't know anything about that."

The rest of what Lister had been about to say was cut off by Tyrian's blunt answer.

After a few seconds of awkward silence, he quickly pulled himself together again and opened his mouth as if to speak.

But a steady knock at the door suddenly cut him off.

The reception room door opened. A refined man walked in, wearing a well-tailored suit, hair combed back without a strand out of place, and a pair of

gold-rimmed glasses on his nose.

“I hope I am not intruding,” the man with the gold-rimmed glasses said with a gentle smile. He bowed politely to the host and guest in the room, then walked straight toward the table. “May I join you?”

“Oh, Mr. Confidential Secretary,” Tyrian looked at the young man for a moment, then suddenly remembered him and smiled. “I recognize your glasses… and your hairstyle.”

Lister turned toward the Confidential Secretary and asked quickly: “Is there news from City Hall?”

The Confidential Secretary nodded and answered softly: “From City Hall.”

Tyrian spoke up from the side: “Let me say this first. I am not interested in the resolutions from your City Hall. We are Rebels…”

He did not finish. The well-dressed Confidential Secretary suddenly turned his face toward Tyrian. As he set a document down on the low table, he looked straight into Tyrian’s eyes and said: “Then what if there is another possibility?”

He paused, pushed the document over, and spoke in a quiet voice:

“Governor Tyrian has arrived in his loyal Frostholm.”

Chapter 442: Documents

Tyrian raised his head. His single eye locked on the confidential secretary in front of him, his face full of an expression that clearly said: “Are you kidding me.”

As the greatest Pirate Lord on the Frost Sea, he had only ever worn such utter shock on his face when he was standing in front of his own father.

He did not touch the pages the other man had pushed over. After he forced his mood to steady a little, he turned and glanced at the man across from him, General Lister.

The Frostholm general’s eyes looked just as stunned as Tyrian felt.

“Looks like this really is a ‘surprise message’,” Tyrian let out a slow breath and spoke in a flat tone. “Even the ‘General’ sitting in front of me didn’t know about this arrangement.”

“Because this is not any kind of ‘arrangement’ at all. It is only a proposal, and a very new one at that,” the confidential secretary adjusted the gold-rimmed glasses on his nose and looked seriously at Tyrian as he said: “Right now the situation in Frostholm is complicated. We do not have much time to discuss every single matter to perfection before we act, so I decided to bring this ‘proposal’ straight here. In the presence of General Lister, we can discuss its feasibility together.”

“Feasibility? You actually think this is feasible?” Tyrian almost laughed. He looked at the confidential secretary as if he were looking at a madman. “Me, the leader of the Sea Mist Fleet, the most vicious and dangerous Pirate

Lord on the Frost Sea. For the past fifty years almost every scary story you Frostholm folk used to frighten your children has been based on me. And now you tell me you want me to be this city's Governor… Mister, we only fought side by side once. I think you have seriously misunderstood the nature of our relationship."

"We fought side by side, and together we held off a crisis that could have destroyed the city-state. Now many people already know it was the Sea Mist Fleet that stepped forward at the last moment to stand with the navy and defend the city. By this time tomorrow, that news will have spread to every corner of Frostholm. City Hall will tell the people this: fifty years ago, the Sea Mist Fleet left only because of a disagreement over course. The Iron Vice Admiral who stormed off in anger never really gave up his duty to defend the city-state."

The confidential secretary paused here. After he saw that Tyrian had no intention of cutting him off, he went on: "Everything can be given a new explanation. Every change can be dressed in a suitable reason. You may think this kind of change would be impossible for the people of Frostholm to accept, but in truth… most ordinary people are not so good at holding on to their 'original convictions' in the face of long-term, one-sided propaganda. Peace in daily life and a real improvement in order will soon outweigh everything else. People's ideas can be 'shaped'. It only takes some time."

Tyrian listened to all of this without interrupting. His expression stayed calm as he stared straight into the confidential secretary's eyes: "It seems you are very good at this kind of thing."

"Every city-state is good at it, including Frostholm in the days of the Queen," the confidential secretary said with no change in his face. "Creating a set of 'ideas' for the people that fits the current social environment and eases the burden on most minds is not a dirty task. Making

fine speeches and then failing to maintain order or keep most people's lives stable is what is shameful.

"Captain Tyrian, City Hall's duty has never been 'justice'. City Hall's duty is to let as many people as possible stay alive."

"…'Let as many people as possible stay alive.' She said that line once too."

"Yes. That sentence is still carved on the door of the domed office," the confidential secretary replied. "What we overthrew back then was only the Queen, not the things that were correct from the start."

Tyrian did not speak for a while. He sat in silence, deep in thought. Only after a long time did he finally speak slowly: "Why do you think I am suited to this position?"

"At first, it was a suggestion brought by Lady Agatha," the confidential secretary said. "But she only mentioned that you and your Sea Mist Fleet might be able to help the city-state restore order. The further decision came from an emergency discussion inside City Hall. As for me, I am actually not sure if you are the right choice. In fact, I still have doubts about this matter. But the others think… before you were a 'pirate', you were first a General of Frostholm, and since the city's written history began, one third of its Sovereigns or Governors have come from the military."

"You are still thinking about things too simply," Tyrian shook his head. "This is not a question of whether the candidate is suitable or not. It is the sum of a whole heap of 'historical leftovers'. Even if, like you said, people's ideas can be shaped, you also said it takes time. Frostholm does not have that time. This city has to restore order as soon as possible, so you had better look for someone el—"

"Captain Tyrian," the confidential secretary suddenly cut him off. "Before you refuse clearly, please look at what I brought. It may give you a new

sense of how ‘feasible’ this is.”

Tyrian paused, then, for the first time, he truly looked at the few pages the other man had placed on the table.

There were no grand titles or fine covers on those documents. When he opened the simple folder, all he saw inside were plainly written ‘proposals’ that read like statements of fact.

Tyrian glanced over the first lines. His expression visibly changed.

He quickly flipped to the end, snapped the folder shut with a sharp sound, and raised his head to stare at the confidential secretary.

The latter still kept a calm face. Before Tyrian could speak, the secretary only gave a small nod.

“First, the Vision disaster that struck the city-state of Frostholm was triggered by Annihilators, but its root cause lay in the unsafe mining carried out by the old City Hall in the deep shafts beneath the city over the past decades. Failing to take enough safety measures in the darkness, plus neglecting or even hiding Anomaly warnings, was the main reason the situation grew so bad.

“Second, all former Governors knew about this and chose to hide it for the sake of profit.

“Third, the Sea Mist Fleet chose to leave Frostholm fifty years ago because of a disagreement over course. The split was tied to such ‘illegal mining’ and to different attitudes toward the foreseeable Vision disaster.

“Fourth, all former Governors carried out a planned and ongoing campaign to smear the Sea Mist Fleet and hide the truth. It covered up the real disagreement between the two sides and guided public hatred toward General Tyrian himself, so people would not look too closely at the problems in the mines.

“Fifth, Governor Winston is under strong suspicion of colluding with Annihilators. Before the Vision disaster broke out, he had already received news but failed to take any effective action. Instead, he chose to flee. He will become a public enemy of the city-state. We believe he has already become a member of the Oblivion cult and will be hunted by Frostholm for all eternity.

“Sixth, the new Governor will reshape order in the city-state. A full investigation of the mines will begin at once, and the settling of accounts with those still alive and responsible will also start immediately.”

Tyrian said nothing. He sat there like a statue carved from deepest ice, staring at the confidential secretary. The weight in his gaze made it hard for anyone in the room to breathe.

But the confidential secretary only drew in a slow breath. Then he took another, thicker bundle of papers from the briefcase at his side.

This file was much thicker and held far more content.

“This is the list,” he said, lifting his head and meeting Tyrian’s heavy gaze. “The first half is the evidence needed for the purge. It includes some records of the illegal mining in the shafts, traces of how Anomaly warnings were covered up, and the orders to twist and slander the Sea Mist Fleet. Right now, for this part we only have the catalogue, but in three days all the evidence will be complete.

“The second half is mainly names. It lists the responsible people who can be arrested and tried, along with their ‘crimes’. Rest assured, they are not innocent. They simply have other charges on record. But that does not matter. Their real crimes no longer matter. Right now the city-state needs them to have ‘colluded with Annihilators’. These people are City Hall’s ‘reserve criminals’.

“And last, there are letters and some pages of diary entries, evidence of Governor Winston’s collusion with the Annihilators. Some of these carry his signature.”

Tyrian did not look at the second stack of papers the man was handing over.

Cold mist slowly rose around him. A fine layer of frost crept across the surface of the tea table. The breath of everyone in the room who could still breathe turned to pale white vapor in the air.

“…Who prepared these things?”

“The former Governors,” the confidential secretary answered calmly. “Every administration prepares one copy, and many ‘backup plans’ as well. They are not necessarily prepared for you. They might be for some other successor, such as the next ‘rebellion’. The last set of materials in front of you was left by Governor Winston. As it happens, he also listed the Sea Mist Fleet as one of his ‘backup plans’. That happens to match Lady Agatha’s ‘suggestion’.”

Tyrian slowly put his hand on the file. Fine ice crystals almost froze it into a solid block. He raised his head and stared into the confidential secretary’s eyes: “So this is enough to define Winston’s role.”

“There is a saying in Frostholm: the dead must give way to the living,” the confidential secretary said quietly. “General Tyrian, you were not born and raised in Frostholm, but I am sure you know this line as well. If defining Governor Winston and the former City Halls in this way lets the city-state regain order quickly, I do not think he, or any former Governor, would mind.”

—

Chapter 443: Origin

The chill in the room seemed to ease a little. The living people who had been shivering from the cold finally let out a small sigh of relief.

But Tyrian still did not answer the series of ‘proposals’ the confidential secretary had put forward. He only stared calmly at the things on the table. It felt as if a century had passed in that silence.

Only when everyone was almost crushed by it did he finally raise his head: “This is the wisdom of maintaining order. I imagine fifty years ago, this wisdom played a great role.”

“You should know what state Frostholm was in back then,” the confidential secretary said. His gaze did not dodge. “Great people do many great things, but the mistakes they make can be just as deadly as their achievements. To keep control of the situation, there were things we had to do. General Tyrian, I studied history. In truth… I have always believed Her Majesty Ray Nora was a remarkable ruler. But that cannot hide the mess left behind after the failure of the Abyssal Trench Project.”

“Yes. You studied history,” Tyrian said calmly. “But I lived it. We both know what it was like in those days, so I am not here to blame you. Honestly, you at least kept Frostholm steady for another half century after that.”

The tension in the confidential secretary’s body finally seemed to relax a little. He leaned forward without thinking: “So, you mean you agree…”

Tyrian still did not answer. He only pressed his hand onto the documents and pushed down.

A freezing force soaked through the paper. Fine ice crystals formed, then shattered in an instant. With a rough, rustling sound, the records that could have left heavy marks in history turned into powder.

The confidential secretary's eyes flew open. General Lister, who had hardly spoken a word this whole time, could not hold back a low exclamation: "What are you doing…"

"These are not what I want," Tyrian raised his head and looked at the Frostholm men opposite him. "I want the real records. What was truly wrong in that mine. How the cultists really slipped into the city-state. Who was responsible and who was not. And Governor Winston's real path in office. Put aside the idea of 'restoring order quickly' and give me the truest firsthand information."

He paused, then went on: "That is what is truly needed to keep control of the situation."

The confidential secretary froze for a moment, then quickly understood: "So you are accepting Frostholm's 'invitation'… but, if I may speak frankly, you still need the documents that were on the table. Of course you can hold the real intelligence, but you also have to find a way to divert the people's attention—"

He hesitated for two seconds here, as if he were making up his mind, then continued: "To be honest, things in the city will get bad next. A lot of the basic infrastructure may have to be shut down for a while. With that 'mud' causing corruption, fuel supplies will grow tight. Food distribution will suffer. Public security will get worse. That will stir up anger everywhere. We must find some way to divert the people's attention. Turning it toward the former government and the old Governor is the most effective way…"

“If fuel is tight, we use reserves. If that is not enough, I will find another way. If food distribution is a mess, we enforce strict supervision and punishment, and we put the whole city under rationing, including the Upper City. If public security breaks down, we impose temporary military control. The people need something to vent their anger on? Then we really go out and seize the cultists. We seize the subversives. We seize the ones who are truly responsible,” Tyrian said sternly. “Of course this whole series of actions will be harder. But at least it will actually solve the problem. And it will truly ‘let more people live’.”

The room went quiet again. You could even hear the sound of people breathing. The always-elegant, always-composed confidential secretary seemed to go a little stiff. Faced with Tyrian’s forceful words, he looked as if he did not quite know how to respond.

Tyrian only gave a light laugh and shook his head: “I will not belittle your work or your solution. Within your limits, you had no better path. You chose what best fit the situation back then. But things are different now. I do not want to repeat these fifty years all over again. Mr. Secretary, the Sea Mist Fleet has its own way of doing things. You might as well raise your expectations a bit.”

The confidential secretary finally seemed to catch up. He blinked, straightened his posture, and fixed his bright gaze on Tyrian: “You can really do all the things you just said?”

“As long as what remains of City Hall’s strength can cooperate to the fullest. As for the rest…” Tyrian stopped on purpose here. Then the corners of his mouth curled in a small smile. “Mr. Secretary, do you know who is most orderly on the Boundless Sea?”

“The most orderly?” The confidential secretary was stunned, as if he had not followed. “The City Navy? Or the long-distance trade fleets?”

“Pirates. The Pirate Lords of the Frost Sea,” Tyrian laughed. “The City Navy always has steady supply ports and safe harbors. The long-distance trade fleets always have the Church’s protection and naval escorts. Only pirates… to stand against the Boundless Sea, we can rely on nothing but strict discipline and order.”

The confidential secretary did not answer for a moment. It seemed he had no idea how to discuss this topic. It clearly lay far outside his daily work and his field of study.

Seeing this, Tyrian only smiled again and reached out to pat the man’s shoulder.

“Relax a little, Mr. Secretary. Compared with fifty years ago, Frostholm’s situation is actually not that bad right now. I still know many ‘partners in trade’. I believe if they learn the truth of what happened here, many of them will be willing to help. At least when it comes to worldly order, you do not need to worry too much. As for the part that lies outside ‘worldly order’…”

Tyrian stopped suddenly and looked up at the window.

The deep veil of night covered the city. The glow of gas lamps wound through the Harbor district like a river of light. At some point the snow had stopped. The clouds had scattered. The cold, pale shine of the World’s Wound bathed the world, and under that light, the city lay peaceful tonight.

“The part outside worldly order… I think my Father will handle that.”

The Pirate Lord hesitated for a few seconds, then finally spoke in a slightly strange tone.

Many people in the room clearly shivered.

“Your Father, He…” General Lister could not help speaking. Without thinking, he even used the divine honorific in his wording. “Is He still watching over Frostholm? Where is He now?”

[Of course He is watching over Frostholm. He might even be standing at a second-floor window right now, looking out. He is living at Oak Street No. 44, in a house he rented from your citizen Service Center…]

A string of answers flashed through Tyrian's mind at once, but after a long struggle he did not dare say any of them out loud.

After all, from the looks of it, the Frostholm people in front of him still had no idea that 'He' was currently inside the city. If Tyrian started talking everywhere about his Father's whereabouts without permission, he would probably earn himself another round of heavy "fatherly discipline" later. He was about to become a Governor. He really could not afford that, in pride or in dignity.

"He is still watching this matter, but I cannot reveal the details," after hesitating for half a day, the Pirate Lord could only give this vague answer. "He is very busy. I am not the only one He has to stay in touch with."

Lister froze for a second, then nodded at once: "Ah… that is understandable."

Tyrian had no idea how Lister was "understanding" it.

The confidential secretary, unable to hold back his curiosity, asked: "Your Father… what does He usually do?"

Tyrian fought down the urge to roll his eye. How was he supposed to know? Ever since his Father came back from Subspace, He had been wrapped in mystery. Who could say what His daily life was like? He could hardly imagine Him acting like some retired old man, going fishing, walking dogs, and feeding pigeons when He had nothing better to do…

The confidential secretary noticed the subtle change in Tyrian's expression. Realizing that he had stepped over the line, he hurried to straighten his face: "I am sorry. I should not have asked."

“It is all right. It is just that ordinary people really should not talk too much about ‘Him’. Let us say it is for the sake of everyone’s mental health. Let us end this topic here,” Tyrian waved his hand and quickly changed the subject.

Then he let out a long breath, rose slowly from the sofa, and walked to the floor-to-ceiling window.

The lights outside were still burning. At several intersections leading into the inner city, you could still faintly see the temporary barricades built during the battle earlier.

When the Sun rose tomorrow, those barricades would be taken down. After that… the city’s new Administrator would have to do everything in his power to restore order here.

The countless lights of the city blocks in the distance reflected in Tyrian’s eye.

“It has been many years since I saw this view. Compared to back then, it has not changed that much.”

General Lister walked over and stood behind Tyrian: “But after today, it should change a great deal.”

“…Fifty years ago, the last royalists left this city. The rebels formed a new City Hall, and I became a rebel. Fifty years later, I have come back. The city still looks the way it did when I left…” Tyrian looked at the distant streets, and a sudden emotion rose in him. “round and round, it all seems to have come back to the starting point. General Lister, tell me, these past fifty years of ours… what did they mean?”

Lister did not answer at once. He seemed lost in thought.

The confidential secretary stepped up beside them, raised his hand, and pointed out the window.

“General Tyrian, this is the meaning.”

Chapter 444: Fishing, Petting the Dog, Feeding the Pigeon

In the pale light of dawn, Vision 001, locked in place by a pair of rune rings, slowly rose from the distant sea horizon. In the spreading glow of the morning sky, the huge sailing ghost ship floated on the endless, calm surface of the sea and slowly gained a soft shine in the morning.

At the far edge of the sea, through the thin morning mist, one could faintly see the silhouette of the city-state of Frostholm. From this distance, the city's wounds and the joys and sorrows of countless people all turned into a blurred shape in the fog, as if they had faded away into the sunlight.

Duncan sat quietly at the edge of the foredeck. He had set up a fishing rod by his side and watched the fishing line reflect the sunlight in the morning glow. Now and then, Duncan raised his head to look into the distance, in the direction of Frostholm.

At this hour, most parts of the city were still very quiet. He did not need to spend much attention on the avatar form he had left in the city-state, so he could finally relax a little and enjoy the peace on the ship.

AI the pigeon walked back and forth on the big wooden barrel beside him. A pile of fries lay on the lid of the barrel, brought aboard from the city-state of Frostholm. Unlike the fries from Pland, the people of Frostholm added special spices when they fried potatoes, giving them a salty, rich smell. AI was clearly very pleased with this. Now and then, it looked up at its Master,

who was fishing, or glanced at the distant sea. The rest of the time, it just lowered its head and ate with all its might.

On Duncan's other side, Shirley lay sprawled over a shorter wooden barrel, writing hard. Her face looked so bitter it was as if she were facing a life-or-death enemy.

Dog lay quietly beside Shirley, holding a copy of Modern Geometry between his two paws. The deck next to them was piled with scrap paper covered in marks and shapes.

Feeling this brief moment of calm, Duncan could not help curling the corners of his mouth. The gloom that had been building in his heart for many days slowly faded.

But clearly, not everyone here was enjoying this "calm."

"Why does Nina get to sleep in down in the cabin… while I have to get up early to rush my homework out here…" Shirley muttered, unable to hold it in. Her face looked so miserable it could have wrung out water. "If I'd known I would only be doing homework back on the ship, I might as well have stayed in the city. At least I could have gone out for a walk once in a while…"

"There isn't much to stroll around in Frostholm right now, and for the foreseeable future life in that city won't be very comfortable," Duncan said calmly when he heard her. "Besides, stop complaining about your homework. You were the one who said your homework got eaten by a stray dog."

Shirley raised her head in protest: "Then why doesn't Nina have to make hers up?"

"Anyone can tell she has already finished," Duncan glanced at Shirley. "Later, Mr. Morris can just give her a full set of review papers to test how

she has been studying on her own. Nina is not like you. She does not need anyone to push her."

Shirley shrank her neck: "Th-then is it possible that I actually already finished…"

Duncan kept a straight face: "How do you spell the plural form of 'pebble'?"

"I haven't memorized that yet…"

"That was on the second page of your previous homework. So you actually didn't even finish either page."

Shirley's face went blank. She fell silent at once, then the young lady let out a long sigh and lowered her head to continue her life-and-death battle with her spelling homework.

Duncan just smiled and shook his head. Then, without meaning to, his gaze fell on the dog beside them. Dog had set the book down for the moment and was holding a pencil between his paws, drawing auxiliary lines on the scrap paper on the deck.

Duncan's gaze made Dog's soul suddenly shiver. Dog's skull gave an involuntary twitch, and the auxiliary line went crooked.

"C-captain?" Dog raised his head nervously. He wanted to avoid Duncan's eyes but did not dare to really turn his head away, so his bony head kept wobbling.

Duncan reached out and rubbed Dog's ugly skull. His expression was a bit strange, and after a few seconds he could not help speaking: "Isn't your study progress a little too fast? I feel like before long you'll be able to keep up with Mr. Morris's lessons directly."

“Huh? I don’t feel that way,” Dog froze for a moment when he heard this. The red light in his hollow eye sockets flickered as if he were dazing out. “I just think all this stuff is pretty interesting… Is there something wrong with learning fast?”

Duncan thought for a moment, then smiled and shook his head: “Forget it, there’s no problem. Learning more is always good. This way, if I average you and Shirley together, at least you two won’t count as illiterate.”

Dog let out a confused “oh.” Duncan let out a small breath and looked back at the fishing rod, which still did not move at all.

He had not caught a single fish all morning.

“After such a great battle, I’m afraid we won’t be able to catch any fish in these waters for a while,” he sighed with regret as he slowly packed up his fishing gear. “The disturbance was so big that even the Deep Sea spawn don’t want to come near this place anymore…”

When Shirley heard this, she could not help raising her head again: “So are we going to leave this place? When will you bring Mr. Morris and Sister Vanna from the city too?”

Duncan stopped packing up the rod and turned his head to look at Shirley: “Did I ever say the matter of Frostholm was completely over?”

“Huh?” Shirley was a little confused. “Isn’t everything already settled? And you even recommended Mr. Tyrian to City Hall. I thought you were going to leave the rest to him to wrap up.”

“It’s true, I do plan to leave all the troublesome affairs in this city to him,” Duncan went on packing as he spoke casually. “But there are still things the Sea Mist Fleet can’t handle. Those things I have to deal with myself. Before they’re taken care of, the Vanished had better not stray too far from here.”

Shirley still did not understand: “Things the Sea Mist Fleet can’t handle? What are they…”

Duncan lowered his eyelids and gave her a calm look: “Where did mirror world Frostholm come from?”

Shirley thought for a moment, then spoke, not very sure: “It was… summoned from the Deep Sea by those cultists?”

“More or less. It was summoned from the Deep Sea. mirror world Frostholm was a ‘product’, something formed by a transformation. Everything we destroyed in that process, including the sacrificial site deep inside mirror world Frostholm, was, in truth, only a ‘summoned thing’. Since there is a summoned thing, there must be a summoning source.”

Shirley finally reacted. Shock slowly appeared in her eyes.

“You mean… the thing under the sea is still there?!”

“If my judgment is right, everything close to the surface, whether those replicas or the mirror world city-state itself, was only the spread and projection of that power,” Duncan said calmly. “It was like a huge plant growing upward from below. In that fierce battle that just ended in Frostholm, we only destroyed the overgrown crown of that runaway plant. Its roots are still there. Don’t forget, back then the Queen of Frostholm had to throw several Deep Dive devices into the sea just to barely touch that thing’s true body. That power has a ‘real form’ in the Deep Sea.”

Shirley finally could not sit still. She almost jumped to her feet: “Huh? Then doesn’t that mean we still have to dive into the Deep Sea and fight that thing? Otherwise won’t it soon make another mirror world?!”

“Soon? It won’t be that quick,” Duncan said with a smile, shaking his head. “Things are not as serious as you think. Even if its true body is still there, it has surely been badly wounded. I have almost completely burned away the

spreading part of it. The rest, after losing the support of those cultists' rituals, is most likely in a state of sleep or dormancy. Even if we really ignored it, it might take another half century before it causes trouble again."

As he spoke, he suddenly stopped and reached out toward the air beside him.

"Isn't that right, Agatha?"

A tuft of ghost-green flame burst into life at Duncan's fingertips. It quickly leaped and spread in the air, forming a whirlpool-like Veil. Inside the blazing Veil stood a blind priestess of the Goddess, dressed in a black gown and wearing an eyepatch, her hands clasped before her chest in a pose of prayer.

Shirley and Dog stared, dumbfounded, at the scene.

"Yes. That is exactly what we have been worrying about," Agatha raised her head. Her slightly husky voice carried a faint, airy quality. "Everyone who knows the truth of the Abyssal Trench Project worries about this. We only destroyed the 'product' that appeared on the surface of the sea, and we had no strength left to destroy the 'true body' that may still be lurking in the Deep Sea."

"We can't just leave it there for another fifty years and then repeat the defense of Frostholm during the next crisis," Duncan said. "I don't mind helping every time, but war always brings many needless victims."

"…The Frostholm of today probably no longer has the strength to build Deep Dive devices like that," Agatha said after a short silence. "It's not just the devices themselves. There is also the other equipment needed to dive, the data, the people, the resources… All of that is something a Frostholm that is still trying to rebuild simply cannot provide."

“Then start preparing as soon as possible. Have your City Hall think of a way,” Duncan said lightly. “If it really doesn’t work, then prepare an iron coffin that can explode in the Deep Sea and put a corpse inside it. Through that medium I can go down to the seabed and take a look. Even though a temporary avatar form can only carry limited power, as long as a stable channel is set up, I should be able to spread the flames down to the bottom of the sea.”

In an age of supernatural awakening, the great edifice was about to collapse.

Flesh was bitter and weak—how could one ascend?

The story began with taking up a ruler that carried the Truth.)

Chapter 445: A Fleeting Glimpse

When Agatha listened to Duncan’s instructions, she immediately thought of the “corpse” that had been used as temporary material for his descent before.

She nodded lightly and did not object: “Yes, I will consider this method.”

Duncan grunted in reply. Then he looked with some curiosity at Agatha, who was appearing in the fiery doorway, studying the faint, blurry scene behind her. He asked casually: “How are things on your side now?”

“The great Cathedral has already returned to normal. Today we are contacting the Cathedrals all over the city, confirming what manpower we still have and counting the losses from this last period,” Agatha answered. There was a hint of relief in her tone. “Last night, just as you said, the city-state passed the night in peace. No Shadows were born in the darkness at all. Even the mental hospital and the cemetery district, which were the most likely to have problems, showed no abnormal changes. That let me breathe a sigh of relief. If things can stay this way, then half of what we have to worry about will vanish.”

“I mean your condition,” Duncan raised his eyebrows. “With this body you have now, won’t such intense work cause problems?”

“I don’t feel tired. Perhaps becoming a corpse is actually a good thing for me now,” Agatha said calmly. “A corpse does not feel fatigue and does not need rest in the usual sense. As long as I can still gain calm from prayer and meditation, I won’t have any problems.”

“You seem to be in the Cathedral’s prayer room?”

“Yes, I’m in the great Cathedral. This used to be Bishop Ivan’s room. It’s very quiet,” Agatha turned her head and glanced at the familiar yet special room. There was a trace of sadness in her voice. “Now, it has been left to me.”

But a strange feeling suddenly rose in Duncan’s heart. He hesitated for a few seconds, then could not stop himself from asking: “You are contacting me like this inside the great Cathedral. Doesn’t Bartok mind?”

Agatha froze at once: “…”

Shirley and Dog beside him were also stunned.

“Captain, how do you always manage to think about things from such an unbelievable angle?” Shirley muttered under her breath. “And that question sounds kind of weird…”

Duncan shot the young lady a blank look: “Don’t interrupt when your Lord is speaking, and don’t use this chance to stop writing. You haven’t written a single word since just now, have you?”

Shirley sighed at once and went back to her life-and-death struggle with her homework. In the flames, Agatha’s projected form finally came back to herself. With a strange look on her face, she turned her head to glance at the nearby statue of the God of Death. Only after a long moment did she turn back: “I have never thought about that question at all…”

Then she paused and asked thoughtfully: “Vanna is at your side. Have you ever asked her this question? How did she answer?”

Duncan thought about it and felt she had a point: “I really haven’t asked. I can ask her when I have time.”

Agatha opened her mouth by instinct as if she wanted to say something, but in the end nothing came out.

After an awkward silence of a few seconds, she finally found another topic: “Besides, I am already prepared to go check the situation inside the Boiling Gold mine.”

“Has the mine already returned to calm?” Duncan raised an eyebrow. “I remember you said we would have to wait at least a few more days.”

“It has mostly calmed down. To be honest… exploring the depths now may still carry some risk, but I don’t plan to wait any longer,” Agatha’s expression grew serious. She clearly had made up her mind. “I can feel that something in the depths is calling to me. This feeling has grown stronger and stronger since this morning. If I keep waiting… I’m afraid I will miss something very important.”

Duncan nodded slightly. After a few seconds of silence he suddenly spoke: “Before you set out, come find me at 44 Oak Street.”

Agatha’s eyes widened in surprise at once: “You are coming with me?”

“I’m also very curious about what was left there.”

“I understand. I’ll come to you before I leave.”

Duncan nodded, then waved his hand to disperse the flames in midair. He let out a breath and lowered his head to look at the empty fishing rod in his hand.

“…Forget it, coming up empty is also part of fishing,” he muttered. He turned his head to glance at Shirley and Dog, who were still by the barrel. “I’m going back to my room first. Dog, keep an eye on Shirley. Make sure she at least copies the first five pages of the vocabulary book. Once her homework is done, she can play however she likes.”

Dog hurriedly stood up, nodding eagerly and wagging his bony tail. Only after Duncan's figure vanished at the stairway not far away did the Abyssal Hound finally breathe out in relief and return to the spot where he had first been lying. But before he lay down, he suddenly looked up at Shirley: "Don't get distracted. Hurry up and write."

"Dog, are you really urging me?" Shirley's shoulders drooped at once. "My hand is sore…"

"I don't even have fingers and I can still write a diary. You at least have two hands with ten fingers," Dog shook his head. As he lay down again, he kept muttering, "Read more books and learn more words, Shirley. Don't get impatient. The captain really is doing this for your own good. Haven't you always wanted a life like other children? I truly can't give you that, but the captain wants to. A being like him has many ways to show favor, but he chooses to care about you and Nina like a human would. Do you know how…"

Shirley quickly waved her hands to beg for mercy halfway through: "Hey, stop, stop. I know, I know, I'm not stupid. Dog, why are you nagging like an old mother…"

Dog grumbled twice more but did not keep lecturing her. Instead he lowered his head and once again studied the geometry textbook in front of him with great interest.

On the pages, words and symbols outlined the knowledge and experience of those who came before. Lines and formulas told the story of how this world worked. The eye sockets filled with bloody red light in Dog's skull were fixed on those chapters that held the wisdom of civilization. In his mind, which belonged to a Abyssal demon, one geometric figure after another, one mathematical formula after another, took shape as he followed the content of the textbook.

There was also a source of red light that flickered, and a series of flashing points of light lined up like a matrix. They flashed between those geometric images and formulas and then passed in an instant.

In the next second, Shirley seemed to sense something and suddenly lifted her head to look toward Dog. Almost at the same moment, Dog snapped out of some strange state. His whole body jumped several meters into the air: “Whoa, what the heck!!”

Shirley was yanked up into the air with him by the chain between them, then crashed down onto the deck with a bang. When she finally got up, dizzy and shaken, the first thing she did was pounce on Dog and grab his head, shaking it hard: “What kind of fit are you throwing?! And what was with you just now? I felt like even your aura changed!”

“I… I don’t know!” Dog’s head creaked as Shirley shook it. He finally managed to pull free, but he still clearly looked dazed. “Just now I think I saw something flash past right in front of me. I didn’t even have time to see what it was… but now everything seems fine.”

AI, who had been pecking at fries nearby, suddenly tilted its head and looked at Dog with interest: “Remote server not responding, please check network connection?”

Dog did not react for a moment and answered without thinking: “Huh?”

But AI only flapped its wings and walked off to the side as if nothing had happened, pacing and muttering to itself: “Top up Q coins? Top up the big monthly card? Top up the battle pass?”

“Don’t pay attention to it. That bird’s brain is even more muddled than Alice’s,” Shirley waved her hand and turned Dog’s head back toward herself. Worry clearly showed on her face. “Are you okay? Did you burn out your brain from doing math problems all day?”

“I’ve never heard of Abyssal demons burning out their brains…” Dog began to doubt himself. “I don’t even know if I have that organ.”

“Of course you haven’t. You’re the only Abyssal demon in the whole world who actually uses his brain. Even if your kind really have brains, they don’t get the chance to burn them out… Hey, hold still. Let me check you over.”

Muttering as she worked, Shirley hurriedly examined Dog from head to toe. Then, through the chain of the symbiotic pact between them, she carefully felt for any change in their shared spiritual level. In the end, she still did not find any problem.

Everything was normal.

“I told you there was nothing wrong,” Dog breathed a sigh of relief and said casually. “Maybe I attracted something while I was reading, and when it was just about to come out, it found out I was a ‘colleague’, so it went back…”

As he muttered, he lay down again and pawed at the scrap paper in front of him.

Shirley grew anxious at once: “Hey, you still plan to keep reading?”

While drawing new auxiliary lines on the paper, Dog replied casually: “I’m only one big problem away, just the last step. I finally got an idea.”

Shirley: “…”

She watched Dog, who was writing and calculating there, with great worry, ready to yank on the chain around her arm at any sign that something was wrong. But until he finished solving that big problem that, in her eyes, looked like an indecipherable heavenly script, nothing happened at all.

Dog tossed the pencil onto the deck and looked up at Shirley.

“See? I told you there was no problem—” There was a trace of comfort in his tone, but soon his gaze fell on the wooden barrel beside them.

“Shirley, you still haven’t finished your homework.”

“Aaah—”

Hearing the girl’s drawn-out wail, Dog only shook his head. Then his eyes fell again on the book he had been reading.

It seemed… there really had been no problem.

But Dog was sure he really had seen something. It was not a “colleague” drawn in by the book, but something else, something more mysterious and more strange.

Just what… had he seen?

Chapter 446: Father Was a Joker

Duncan was just about to step into the captain's cabin when he suddenly stopped and turned to look over his shoulder.

There seemed to be some movement from the bow deck. Through the faint sense coming from the Vanished, he could tell that the noise came from Shirley and Dog.

But nothing was actually wrong over there.

"So much fuss over a bit of homework." Duncan muttered this, shook his head, and then walked toward the enchanted sea chart.

Goathead, who had been steering carefully at the edge of the chart table, let out a burst of squeaking wood. He turned his head toward Duncan, and his two black obsidian eyes almost seemed to light up: "Ah! The great Captain Duncan has come to the side of his loyal First Mate—what have you gained today…"

"No fish today." Duncan glanced at Goathead. "After all the commotion before Frostholm, we probably won't be able to catch any fish around here for a while."

The string of flattery Goathead had just brewed up was forced back down at once. His wooden neck creaked as it swayed from side to side twice. After a long moment, he finally choked out: "Ah… then at least you have gained a quiet morning. The sea breeze is pleasant today, and the sunlight is good. It is a fine day to roam the sea. If you are interested, we could sail near Cold Harbor…"

“Not interested. For now, I don’t plan to let the Vanished get close to any city-state.” Duncan cut Goathead off just as he was about to start rambling again. Duncan’s gaze fell casually onto the enchanted sea chart in front of him.

Mist slowly rose and fell on the enchanted sea chart. In the drifting haze, a clear route was marked out. It showed the path the Vanished had taken on its way north. Around the phantom image of the ship that stood for the Vanished, there was the projection that represented Frostholm, and another that glowed with a faint green light: the Sea Mist.

At that moment, the Sea Mist was moored at the edge of the city-state of Frostholm.

“The Sea Mist looks pretty quiet over there…” Duncan’s eyes rested on the projection of the Sea Mist. The corner of his mouth suddenly lifted a little, as if he had thought of something amusing. “Seems like everything is going smoothly.”

“Smoothly? Ah, Captain, I feel you have come up with another great plan?” Goathead perked up at once. He craned his neck toward the enchanted sea chart and started chattering: “What are you planning? To topple a city-state that is still weak and shaken? Or to take this chance to fully reclaim the Sea Mist, which once left the fleet without permission? As expected of you. What you plan is never only…”

Duncan gave Goathead a silent look. “Are robberies and schemes to overthrow things the only ideas in that head of yours? Are there no positive options?”

Goathead thought for a moment and changed his wording: “Do you plan to personally help Frostholm rebuild order so it can get through this crisis? Or will you give Tyrian some mental guidance, so he can shed his shameful rebel status and return to the proper and glorious path?”

Duncan looked at him with a strange expression. “How did you come up with that?”

“Captain, maybe you haven’t noticed, but I do have some powers of observation. And after spending this time together, I have come to understand you better and better.” Goathead slowly turned his neck. His dark eyes could not show any feeling, but his tone clearly carried a bit of pride and ease. “You won’t just ignore Frostholm as it is now. Unlike Pland, Frostholm suffered far more damage in this disaster. If you really left it alone, there would be big trouble. And you…”

He paused here, as if searching for the right words. After a short while, he went on slowly: “And you are full of humanity.”

For a moment, Duncan said nothing. He simply fixed his calm gaze on Goathead’s eyes, which were so black they seemed able to swallow light. After a long time, he finally broke the silence in a low voice: “Your observation is sharp.”

Goathead hesitated. Then there was a crack from inside his neck: “Th-this… this sounds like the kind of thing someone says right before silencing a witness…”

But Duncan laughed and shook his head. “See? You still don’t understand me enough. I don’t mind a sharp-eyed fellow. It saves me a lot of trouble.”

After he spoke, Duncan waved his hand and did not bother with whatever reaction Goathead might have next. He stood up and looked toward the ancient round mirror not far away.

A pale flame rose quietly in his gaze. The mirror’s surface grew deep and black. In the calm spreading light and shadow, the hurried figure of Tyrian running over slowly came into focus.

“Good morning, Tyrian. I hope I did not disturb your rest.” Duncan looked calmly at the “Pirate Lord” who had clearly run all the way to the mirror. A slight smile touched Duncan’s lips. “How did you sleep last night?”

Tyrian in the mirror looked nervous. He took several deep breaths before he calmed down. His stiff smile pulled at the corners of his mouth. “Fa… Father, good morning. I was just about to look for you—oh, I slept well enough last night. Thank you for asking.”

“You sound far too stiff when you talk to me. No need to be so tense.” Duncan adjusted his sitting position and looked at the figure in the mirror with a half-smile. “What is it? Did my other form scare you?”

“N-no!” Tyrian straightened at once, like a student who had suddenly been called on in class. “I just feel a bit more respect and awe for you…”

“That’s enough. I only hope you can relax a little. None of my forms should make you this nervous.” Duncan shook his head. “You said you were just about to look for me. Is something wrong?”

Tyrian hesitated. He seemed to be sorting out his thoughts and weighing how he should start. After a moment, he spoke in a careful tone: “It’s about Frostholm. I don’t know how to explain it to you, but it seems they want to…”

The Pirate Lord got stuck. He did not know if some things should be said or not. But just then, Duncan’s voice suddenly sounded and cut him off: “Let me guess what your next position will be. General of the city-state of Frostholm? A high-ranking official in City Hall? Or… did they simply ask you to be Governor?”

Tyrian, who had been struggling over how to phrase things, froze and looked up in shock.

“How did you…”

“Simple. It was my idea—to let the Sea Mist fleet enter the city.” Duncan looked completely open about it. “Otherwise, what else could have pushed that chaotic City Hall to move so fast and agree so easily? You know how their procedures work.”

The expression on Tyrian’s face changed in a very visible way. In his eyes there was clearly a mood like, [I spent the whole night scratching my head over my life and future, and in the end I find out my own father was just having fun with it.] He opened his mouth several times as he stared at the mirror, but in the end he did not dare voice that disrespectful thought. He only looked at Duncan with a tangled, confused expression. “Why would you do that…”

“It’s simple. Frostholm needs you, and you need Frostholm.” Duncan put away the faint smile at the corner of his mouth that belonged to a man who enjoyed the joke. His expression turned serious as he looked at Tyrian. “Inside the city, the chaotic situation needs a strong enough force to calm it and comfort the people. From the outside, Frostholm’s navy has been badly hurt. The whole city-state urgently needs strong protection. So who else has both a firm hand and experience in ruling, and also commands a powerful fleet?”

Duncan shifted his position a little and leaned forward, looking into Tyrian’s eyes.

“It looks like you have already accepted their invitation. Just as I said, Frostholm needs you—and you need it.”

Tyrian’s gaze seemed to dodge a little. “I’ve been a pirate for fifty years. Changing my way of life doesn’t sound too bad.”

“Tell the truth.”

“…After all, you personally protected that place. I don’t want to see your effort wasted…”

“Tell the truth.”

“I admire the tenacity the people of Frostholm showed. In the face of disaster, they did not back down. Even before you stepped in to help, they never surrendered. I admit it. I don’t want to see those people suffer in the days to come.”

Duncan did not speak. He only looked quietly at Tyrian.

Tyrian shrugged. “On the other hand, I don’t want to see a place Her Majesty Ray Nora once protected fall into a long, hopeless Dark Age.”

Duncan still did not speak.

“All right…” Tyrian finally sighed, looking helpless. “All of the above.”

“Good. Be an honest man, especially in front of me.” Duncan looked away, and his posture relaxed again. “So, what is your position now?”

“They want me to be Governor.” Tyrian tugged at the corner of his mouth in a complicated smile. “They even… took out a whole stack of plans they had prepared long ago.”

For a moment, Duncan said nothing, as if he had fallen into a short thought. After a few seconds, he let out a slow breath. “They are a bit bolder than I expected.”

Tyrian hesitated. There was a hint of inquiry in his eyes. “Do you have any advice for me?”

“Why ask for my advice?” Duncan laughed. “You once served the Queen of Frostholm. You have led the Sea Mist fleet for fifty years. You have dealt with every city-state on the Frost Sea. I don’t think I can give you any tips about being Governor.”

“I just want to hear your thoughts.”

Duncan fell silent in thought. After a brief pause, he spoke softly: “Then do the job well. Do all you can. In this cold world, there are already very few things people can rely on.”

“…I understand.”

“Good.” Duncan answered casually. Then he suddenly turned his head and glanced at the enchanted sea chart beside him. “Also, there is one more thing.”

Hearing this, Tyrian straightened up at once. “Please, tell me.”

Duncan looked at the enchanted sea chart. On it, at a point almost overlapping with the Sea Mist, the phantom image of the White Oak was quickly coming into view.

He turned back, smiling at Tyrian. “In a moment, make sure you hold on to something.”

Tyrian froze. “Huh?”

Duncan waved his hand and casually dispelled the flame in the mirror. At the very instant the fire faded, Tyrian’s muffled shout came from the other side of the glass—

“Hey, wh—what’s going on?!”

Chapter 447: A New Member of the Vanished Fleet

A fast exploration ship with a gleaming white hull suddenly rose out of the sea. Its side almost scraped the Sea Mist's stern, and the violent swell of water threw both ships into heavy rocking.

Even the Undying sailors cried out in this situation.

Tyrian rushed onto the deck. At first glance, he saw his subordinates running toward the stern. Among them, the bare, shiny head of First Mate Aiden stood out at once. At the far end of the deck lay the "uninvited guest" that was almost pressed against the Sea Mist.

"What in the world is going on?"

Tyrian ran the last few steps to Aiden's side, grabbed his shoulder, and shouted the question.

"No idea. It was a ship that suddenly popped out of nowhere. I almost ordered the guns to fire by reflex," Aiden answered quickly. "Everyone is still on edge. Right now, everyone is jumpy about anything that 'comes out of the sea', and that thing just appeared…"

Tyrian let go of his First Mate and ran toward the stern. By the time he arrived, dozens of people had already gathered there. The nervous sailors were pointing rifles and pistols at the other ship. Several seamen had taken their positions beside the close-defense guns at the stern. The tension in the air was so thick it felt like sparks might start flying at any moment.

Tyrian looked across the rail. On the other ship, just a short distance away, a crowd of sailors had also rushed out. From their clothes, they looked like ordinary seafarers from a civilian ship. Someone on their stern platform was waving signal flags. They looked just as panicked as the people on the Sea Mist.

Tyrian frowned. He was just about to try to figure out what ship it was when a harsh squeal from a horn sounded by his ear. A loud, steady voice came from the other vessel's broadcast system right after:

"Our deepest apologies. This is the White Oak of the Vanished Fleet. This is our ship's first time performing a Spirit Realm surfacing operation, and due to an error in handling we nearly rammed your vessel… Repeat, this is the White Oak, of the Vanished Fleet…"

As he listened to the broadcast, Tyrian's face froze at once. Aiden, who had just run up behind him, almost slipped. Shiny beads of sweat seemed to pop out on the bald man's head. His voice even went slightly off pitch: "Captain, wh-what did they say? Who did they say they were?"

Tyrian did not answer. The first thing that popped into his mind was the warning Father had given him just before their link was cut, and that odd smile Duncan had worn before the image in the mirror faded.

His expression shifted in a subtle way. Then, out of the corner of his eye, he saw something. He walked to the edge of the deck and looked down.

The reflection of the "White Oak" showed on the water below. But in that reflection, what appeared was a ghost ship wrapped in shadow and thick smoke.

He finally remembered where he had seen that somewhat familiar ship before.

Back in that battle in the fog, this was the storm of a ship that had raced across the battlefield like the wind. No one could figure out where it came from—now they had met again.

By now, the sailors on the Sea Mist had also noticed the strange reflection of the other ship in the water. Aiden, too, remembered where he had seen it. He looked up at Tyrian in shock and doubt. “Captain, are they the old captain’s…”

“…Father always has his plans.” The muscles at the corner of Tyrian’s eye twitched, but he still tried to keep his tone calm. “Honestly, I never thought there would be people in this age who would openly shout over a loudspeaker that they are members of the ‘Vanished Fleet’… Where in the world did Father find this bunch?”

“Maybe they know where the Sea Mist came from?” Aiden said, not very sure. “What should we do? Say hello? Invite them aboard? We have to figure out what they want…”

Tyrian suddenly felt a dull ache in his teeth.

“Use the wireless and call them openly. Ask them to send a representative over. Also, tell them to stop yelling ‘Vanished Fleet’ over their speakers. Our ship is not the only one in the Harbor district.” The Pirate Lord, who was about to become the city’s Governor, said this helplessly. Then he added: “And let the Harbor know not to panic. They must have seen the White Oak suddenly pop out of the sea too.”

At a time like this, anything that suddenly rose out of the sea was enough to scare people half to death.

“Yes, Captain.”

Aiden accepted the order and hurried off.

After a while, the Sea Mist finally established normal communication with the strange White Oak. After a simple exchange and explanation, the other side agreed to send a representative over for a talk.

Not long after, Tyrian met the representative they sent. A middle-aged man, tall and lean, with slightly wavy brown short hair and a sharp, capable look, came aboard the Sea Mist in a seafarer's uniform, bringing a young priest with him.

"Captain Tyrian—it's an honor. I have long heard of your deeds." The middle-aged man stepped onto the deck with a bright, friendly smile and reached out his hand to Tyrian. "I am Gus, First Mate of the White Oak. And this is our ship's priest, Mr. Jensen."

Tyrian felt a bit dazed. He had never thought that, from that eerie "twin phantom ship" that could sail through mirror world, the Spirit Realm, and other abnormal sea regions, such a person would walk out.

A man with a bright smile, a solid body of flesh and blood, friendly and warm, a perfectly healthy and normal person.

He was not mad or raving. His limbs were whole. There was no sign of mental problems or bodily mutation at all. This was the new member of the Vanished Fleet? Someone under Father's favor?

Even though many questions flashed through his mind in that instant, Tyrian still reached out on reflex and shook First Mate Gus's hand.

"Tyrian Abnomar, captain of the Sea Mist. I don't think I need too much introduction." He looked at the "bright and sunny normal man" in front of him, who claimed to be First Mate of the White Oak. Tyrian's eyes still held some doubt. "You said you are… members of the Vanished Fleet?"

"Yes. New members." First Mate Gus answered with a smile. At the same time, he was also sizing up this famous Pirate Lord, and he could not help

feeling puzzled in his heart.

The single eye was a bit frightening, but Tyrian's attitude was on the whole friendly. His gaze was calm and rational. His body did not show the terrible damage that surrounded the Undying sailors nearby. He did not look at all like a madman with mental problems or a lunatic twisted by the Elder Gods' corruption.

This was Captain Duncan's eldest son? How could he not look insane at all?

At this first meeting between two broad-sense "members of the Vanished Fleet", they both, at the same time, quietly questioned the other's mental state. Then, together, they put away that not-so-kind thought and shared a smile.

"I saw you on the battlefield before." Tyrian was the first to break the slightly awkward silence. "You roared through the thick fog back then. It left quite an impression."

"We were under orders at the time to head to Frostholm in the mirror world," First Mate Gus explained. "We couldn't afford to delay such an important task."

"Father's orders?" Tyrian asked without thinking. Then his gaze fell on the young priest named Jensen, and his eyes took on a subtle look. "You even have a ship's priest… Has the Deep Sea Church become this open-minded?"

priest Jensen looked a bit embarrassed. He shrugged with a helpless smile. "At least for now, the Goddess has not sent down any punishment."

"Don't you have a small Cathedral on your ship too?" First Mate Gus looked up at the striking shipborne Cathedral at the Sea Mist's stern.

"…That is true."

Tyrian choked on his words for a second, then gave an awkward little laugh. At the same time, though, something else crossed his mind—

On the Vanished, there was also a “priest” miss from the True Gods’ Church.

If Father could even bring an Inquisitor from Pland onto his ship, then having a few ship priests in the Vanished Fleet did not seem strange at all.

Realizing that it was probably best not to dig too deeply into secrets in the realm of Gods, Tyrian quickly cut off his train of thought. He straightened his expression and asked curiously: “You surfaced in such a hurry here. Do you have another mission?”

“Oh, we are here to pick up our captain,” First Mate Gus explained at once.

“Your captain?”

“Captain Lawrence led a marine squad into the mirror world world to fight earlier. Later, he returned to the city-state in the Mortal Realm together with Frostholm’s Gatekeeper. We just received word that he is coming back to the ship,” First Mate Gus said patiently. “But it seems they ran into a bit of trouble over there, so Lady Martha ordered us to surface and receive them…”

“Ran into trouble?” Tyrian frowned without thinking. He was about to ask for details when his chief sailor walked quickly up to them.

The chief sailor came to his side and gave a quick, quiet report.

The expression on Tyrian’s face slowly turned strange.

First Mate Gus noticed this and could not help asking: “May I ask what has happened…”

“Your captain—is he an older man in a white coat, maybe about fifty or sixty, who looks like a ghost?”

First Mate Gus stared for a moment, then answered a bit uncertainly: “He… doesn’t look like a ghost under normal conditions, but the rest fits.”

“Then that’s him.” Tyrian spread his hands. “Your captain is running all over the Upper City with a dozen heavily armed ghost sailors and a very loud mummified corpse. Now they have been ‘invited’ into the security bureau. If I’m right, they got lost, and it seems they don’t know how to ‘turn off’ the spirit form flames on their bodies, so they caused a panic among the citizens.”

Gus: “Ah…”

“But don’t worry. The security bureau knows they aren’t enemies. Witnesses saw them fighting the monsters in the city and covering the Guard Corps, so they won’t be in real trouble.”

“Uh…”

“Also, Gatekeeper and Archbishop Lady Agatha has already gone to meet them. With the great Cathedral vouching for them, your captain should be back soon.”

“Oh…”

“In the future, try not to publicly announce that you are ‘members of the Vanished Fleet’ whenever you feel like it. Mainly because… that identity is very sensitive.”

“…All right.”

Chapter 448:

The room in the Security Bureau was very warm, and the lights were bright. Even with the city in its current chaos, this place still looked neat and orderly—and they even had tea and coffee.

“Name?”

“Lawrence Creed.”

“Occupation?”

“Captain. Captain of the White Oak.”

“Affiliated guild?”

“The Explorer Association. I have full senior Explorer qualifications, including history, occult studies, and certificates in navigation and related fields. And… uh, that’s it.”

“Reason for coming to Frostholm?”

Lawrence looked up at the bright electric light above, thought for a few seconds, and said: “Honestly, I first came to deliver cargo… the shipment your city’s Cathedral ordered.”

The young clerk sitting across the table scribbled on the paper, then looked up after a few quick strokes. With a friendly yet obviously nervous smile, he said: “All right, I’ve written it down. Please don’t mind, it’s just routine. After all, if you come here, we have to leave some record. Frostholm thanks you for your help—would you like another sugar cube?”

“Ah, no need, thank you.” Lawrence waved his hand a bit awkwardly, picked up the coffee cup and took a sip. But since he was still in the Ghost state, he could taste nothing and feel no warmth or cold. So he set the cup down again and turned to glance behind him.

The sailors wreathed in Ghost flames sat in a row on the chairs in the back half of the room. These rough fellows had almost emptied all the tea and snacks the office had prepared. They did not mind at all that taste was numb in spirit form. They were eating purely on the principle that, since they had come all this way, they could not leave at a loss.

They showed none of the nervousness one should have after being “invited” into the Security Bureau for disturbing the peace. Of course, that was normal. After all, his group had indeed been “invited” in by the constables in a very polite, even slightly tense and reverent way.

Thinking of this, Lawrence could not help feeling another wave of embarrassment. But with his face wrapped in flame, others probably could not see his expression.

“I heard that at first you were in the Cathedral district helping the Gatekeeper. Why were you wandering all over the Upper City afterward? And why did you… cause such a big commotion?”

The young clerk in charge of registration across the table asked, curious and cautious.

“It was just some… small accidents,” Lawrence said, with a hint of shame in his tone as he tried hard to find a way to explain the messy situation. How was he supposed to explain it? Say straight out that after leading a band of sailors in a big brawl, they still had energy to burn, so they decided to stroll around the city and buy some local specialties to take back to Pland? And then, because the Ghost fire was hard to control, the flames

they had finally managed to suppress somehow flared up again when the Sun rose?

That really had been literally “flared up”—they were walking at a crossroads, in full view of everyone, when they suddenly caught fire.

Anomaly 077, who had been wrapped in a robe and well hidden in the middle of the group, was so startled that he bolted straight out from among the sailors onto the sidewalk.

The result was that in five minutes they drew constable teams from three streets over. Men, women, and children all through the Upper City were running around reporting them.

Lawrence thought for a long time and decided he really could not say the truth. Mainly, if he just started talking, he might end up “ruining the good name of the Lost Home Fleet”—and though the Lost Home Fleet did not seem to have much of a good name in the mortal world anyway, it should at least not be that kind of reputation.

So he could only give another awkward smile and fob it off: “We were very curious about this city and, for a moment, forgot to hide our tracks…”

The crackling bang of flames suddenly sounded. Lawrence casually slapped the green tongues of fire on his arm, checked whether the armrest of the chair had been scorched by the spirit flame, and, once he was sure it was fine, looked up again. He kept watching the young man across from him with a sincere smile.

“…Could you please put out this awful fire for a moment?”

“I’m trying—though it might not look like I’m trying very hard.”

“…Thank you for your cooperation. You can wait here for a bit. I still have a few questions for your… subordinates.”

The young clerk wiped the cold sweat from his forehead and worked hard to keep his calm, friendly expression. Then he took a deep breath and turned his head toward another figure beside the table—a fellow who was also waiting for “routine procedures” and who looked suspicious no matter how you saw him.

It was a shriveled, terrifying mummified corpse, wearing an Old Era sailor’s smock and a seafarer’s cap that did not quite fit.

Noticing the gaze fall on him, the mummified corpse immediately lifted his head. A ghastly smile spread across his face. “Questioning? I know how that works. Go ahead, go ahead.”

“Uh… all right,” the clerk said, wiping the cold sweat on his forehead again. In his heart he was cursing the supervisor who had scheduled him for duty here today and envying his colleagues who were out on street patrol, while he tried hard to keep his voice steady. “Name?”

“‘Sailor.’ That’s what I’m called,” the mummified corpse answered at once.

“Sai… uh, fine. Occupation?”

“Anomaly.”

The clerk raised his head in a daze. “Huh?”

“Anomaly,” the mummified corpse said honestly, pointing at his own shriveled head. “Or, more precisely, Anomaly 077.”

The clerk seemed to turn into a statue. A few seconds later, the distinct sound of a gulp finally reached Lawrence’s ears.

“Ahem, there’s a very complicated reason for that,” Lawrence coughed twice. His voice finally snapped the clerk out of his near mental blank. “Don’t worry. When the person in charge of your Church gets here, I’ll find a way to explain it all properly and get it recorded.”

Even listening to the old captain, the clerk still seemed lost. His expression shifted quickly several times before he opened his mouth, as if to say something. But before he could speak, a gust of wind wrapped in pale dust suddenly swept through the office—

The Ashen Wind swirled, and from within it stepped a blind Goddess official in a black long dress. A slightly airy, hoarse female voice followed: “I am here.”

The clerk, whose nerves were stretched almost to breaking and whose sanity was starting to waver, suddenly seemed to grab a lifeline. He almost sprang up from his chair. “Ah, Lady Agatha! You’re finally here! The situation here is a bit…”

“I know. The situation is complicated, so I came to handle it myself,” Agatha said, cutting off the unlucky clerk with a wave of her hand. Then she turned to Lawrence. Her pale lips curled slightly, though there was something odd in her tone. “I thought you had already left.”

“We were planning to leave…” Lawrence gave a dry laugh, but the tense strings inside him still loosened a little. No matter what, he and this Gatekeeper before him had fought side by side. The whole process had been full of chaos, weirdness, eldritch things, and countless unexpected twists, but at least one thing was certain: they were “the same kind of people.”

Agatha on the opposite side also seemed to relax a little. She waved to the clerk beside her, signaling that he could go. The young man looked as if he had been granted amnesty and fled from the sparsely populated office as fast as he could.

Then Agatha sighed again, full of helplessness and fatigue. After signaling Captain Lawrence and his people to stay calm, she focused her mind and said inwardly: “I’ve found them. They’re all here at the Security Bureau… The situation? Very good, and their appetites look very good as well… Yes,

I understand. We'll handle the follow-up… Don't worry. They haven't actually caused much trouble, just stirred up a bit of citizen panic. You know, everyone's nerves are pretty tight right now…

"There's one more thing to report. There's a runaway state Anomaly… yes, a runaway state Anomaly, number 077, name 'Sailor'. This mummified corpse has been acting together with them…

"You want them to come to you? Understood—it's Oak Street… ah, all right, I understand."

After a long while, Agatha finally let out a small breath and lifted her head to "look" at Captain Lawrence.

Even with the black cloth over her eyes, it still felt as if a solid gaze pierced the thick bandage, making the old captain feel a bit of pressure.

He gradually realized what was happening. "You were talking to 'Him' just now?"

"Yes. And He has given orders," Agatha nodded, her expression turning serious. "He wants you to go see Him."

"Go see Him?" Lawrence's heart gave a jolt, and a trace of tension slipped into his voice. "You mean…"

"The Vanished is currently waiting in the waters off Frostholm. Captain Tyrian will tell you the general location. The Sea Mist and your White Oak are moored in the same harbor right now; you'll see them as soon as you reach the docks," Agatha said calmly. "Go out to sea to find Him. Don't worry about missing Him. When you get close, your ship will know what to do. Just let it sail on its own."

Lawrence swallowed unconsciously and looked at the sailors he had brought. They all stood up, every gaze showing clear tension.

Then he turned his head and saw Anomaly 077 already sprawled on the floor, inching his way toward the door.

A few sailors rushed over and, ignoring the mummified corpse's violent struggling, dragged him back.

Lawrence slowly pulled his gaze away from that little chaos and looked uneasily at Agatha in front of him.

"Did He… say what He wants us for?"

"No. But He said it's just a friendly invitation and that you shouldn't be too nervous…"

As soon as she finished, before Lawrence could speak, Anomaly 077 burst out howling and thrashing under the sailors' grip: "I! Don't! Believe!! It!!"

"Make him shut up," Lawrence shouted over his shoulder. Then he took several deep breaths, forcing himself to calm down before giving Agatha a slight nod. "I understand. I will go to the meeting."

"Relax. You really don't need to be so tense," Agatha said with a smile. "Honestly… He's far more gentle and friendly than anyone imagines."

"I know," Lawrence said with a wry spread of his hands. "But tension isn't something you can just get rid of. I guess that will only change after we keep the appointment and actually meet 'Him' face to face."

"In any case, I wish you all the best," Agatha nodded slightly, then casually asked, "Is there anything else? Frostholm is in a bad state right now, but as long as it's something I can do, I'll try my best to help."

When Lawrence heard that, he actually looked thoughtful. Then he reached into his coat to feel around.

A moment later, he pulled out a sheet of paper that looked faintly translucent, burned thin by spirit form flames, and handed it to Agatha.

“What is this?”

“It’s the cargo list—the shipment your Cathedral ordered. We’ve already delivered everything to the harbor,” Lawrence said, with a hint of hesitation in his tone. “Can… this bill still be settled?”

Agatha froze on the spot.

The Gatekeeper of the city-state of Frostholm, the temporary Archbishop, the Envoy of the Flame Usurper, the firm and clever Lady Agatha—had truly not seen this coming.

After more than ten seconds of silence, this “Blind Nun” finally nodded, speaking as if through clenched teeth. “…We’ll settle it.”

Chapter 449:

The winch turned and the steel cable pulled taut. The metal “iron cage” rattled and creaked as it descended, while darkness spread outside the cage. Dim gas lamps were set into the sides of the shaft wall, driving back the depths of the mine’s darkness and bringing a limited but necessary sense of safety.

Agatha stood at the edge of the Shaft Lift. Her “gaze” passed through the railing, looking into the shaft that stretched ever downward. The black cloth over her eyes, like a veil of night, hid both her sight and most of her expressions, leaving others almost no way to guess what she was thinking.

“It’s so deep down here…” A voice suddenly broke the calm inside the Shaft Lift. Alice stood nervously behind Duncan, looking up at the gas lamp light sliding past on both sides of the shaft wall as she spoke with a bit of fear. “I feel like we’re about to go straight through the city-state and fall into the sea…”

“Dropping without a break will give you that illusion,” Morris’s voice came from one corner of the cage. The old scholar was curiously examining the inner structure of this large Shaft Lift as he spoke without turning his head. “In fact, we’ve probably only gone down two or three hundred meters.”

“Oooh—” Alice drew out the sound. It was hard to say whether she really understood how deep “two or three hundred meters” was. In any case, the doll girl’s face showed an expression of “that sounds amazing.”

Duncan paid no attention to the exchange between Alice and Morris. He moved over to stand beside Agatha, who was silently standing at the edge of the car, and glanced at this Gatekeeper. “You look troubled.”

“…I just couldn’t help thinking of many things once we went down the shaft,” Agatha said after two seconds of silence, her tone complicated. “They say… ‘the other me’ stood right here back then, leading the members of the exploration unit down this shaft into the depths of the Boiling Gold mine…”

Her voice was hoarse, with a hint of hesitation.

“Back then, ‘she’ seemed to have already sensed the truth about herself. According to the details described by several Guardians who went down with her, she already carried a strange, resolute air at the time. No one knew why…”

“If that ‘replica’ really restored most of your thoughts and memories, it’s not hard to imagine her realizing the truth about herself,” Duncan said quietly. “Even a replicant can have a strong will and a noble heart.”

Agatha did not speak for a while, as if lost in tangled, heavy thoughts. After a long time, she suddenly broke the silence. “I’m just wondering… what she was thinking about then, what she was remembering. Was she ever afraid, or did she regret it? She had my memories, yet only a few days of real life. Faced with all this… would she hold any hatred in her heart?”

Duncan turned his head and fixed his gaze quietly on Agatha.

After a moment of that gaze, he slowly spoke. “If it were you, would you harbor hatred or regret your own decision?”

“No.”

“Then clearly, she wouldn’t either.”

“But…” Agatha went on. “But… I think I would still have some regrets. When I died in the dark, I would think of the city-state under the sunlight, of the familiar people and things in the city. And if I were a replicant, I would also regret that I could not cross Bartok’s great gate, because I wouldn’t know whether I had a soul. I…”

She stopped and took a gentle breath, her tone holding a touch of sadness. “Yes. If it were me, I would feel regret.”

Duncan looked at her for a long time before withdrawing his gaze and turning to the darkness slowly rising around them and the lights within it. “Then she would too.”

Agatha fell silent for a moment, as if talking to herself, yet also quietly asking: “What will we see down there…”

“I don’t know either. That’s why we have to come down and check,” Duncan said, glancing back at the others in the car—Alice, Morris, and Vanna, who stood in the middle of the Shaft Lift with her arms folded and eyes closed, resting. Besides those three, plus Agatha and himself, there was no one else here.

“You didn’t bring any subordinates and only called on us. Was that out of caution?”

“I don’t know what will happen below. It might be corruption left behind by the Elder Gods, or a ‘truth’ that can spread. When the situation is unclear, bringing ordinary Guardians and priests would only add more variables,” Agatha said frankly. “You and your followers are clearly not afraid of those things.”

Duncan listened, just smiled, and said nothing.

Just then, the car began to slow quickly. With the creak of automatic mechanisms and a final clang as the “iron cage” touched bottom, the Shaft

Lift finally reached the mine floor.

“We’re here,” Agatha said, lifting her head to look outside. She opened the gate and stepped out first, reminding the people behind her without thinking: “Be careful. They’ve only done a preliminary cleanup here—the emergency crews pulled out hours ago. Where we’re heading next is the truly ‘unknown deep darkness.’”

As she spoke, she suddenly stopped and turned to Duncan with a hint of awkwardness. “Of course, these warnings might be a bit redundant for you…”

Duncan waved his hand to show he didn’t mind and looked into the depths of the tunnel. Only a few gas lamps shed dim light in the darkness, making the passage ahead even more hazy. Suspicious piles lay everywhere, and an uneasy, eerie air hung over everything. It was hardly a comforting scene.

“I shouldn’t have had Nina go back to the ship so early,” he said casually. “A place this dark would be perfect for her.”

“Or maybe she’d get startled by something in the dark and blow up the whole tunnel with one several-thousand-degree sneeze,” Morris couldn’t help muttering. “I do not recommend you take Nina into any dark, cramped space—she’s still young and startles easily.”

Duncan shrugged. “Kids have to grow up. She’s almost done with high school.”

Morris’s expression went a bit stiff. The corner of his mouth twitched several times before he spoke, choosing his words. “Captain, under normal circumstances, a child graduating from high school chooses a party or a trip to celebrate adulthood, not an expedition in a mine tunnel tainted by Elder Gods’ corruption as a ‘graduation rite’…”

Duncan laughed cheerfully, then as if suddenly thinking of something, turned his head and asked Vanna: “How did you spend your coming-of-age rite at seventeen?”

He was only asking casually, wanting a reference for the day he would celebrate Nina’s or Shirley’s own coming-of-age rite.

Vanna hadn’t expected the topic to suddenly land on her. The beautiful warrior maiden froze for a moment, her face quickly showing a bit of embarrassment. As she walked forward, she muttered under her breath: “… Studying for make-up exams after a delayed school year…”

Duncan: “…”

The mood turned a bit awkward. Duncan could only spread his hands helplessly, while Agatha, walking in front, suddenly looked back, as if casting an incredulous “gaze” at him.

“What is it?” Duncan asked offhandedly.

“No matter how many times I see it, the way you interact with your followers still feels truly strange,” she said. “You, after taking back your humanity, are completely opposite to the you in the legends of the past century. I think I can somewhat understand why Captain Lawrence of the White Oak and his subordinates are such an interesting group.”

Duncan had no reaction to the first part of her words, but his expression turned odd at the end. As soon as Agatha finished speaking, he said: “Let me stress again, while everyone on the White Oak technically counts as my subordinate, I’m really not familiar with them…”

Agatha nodded. “Yes, you’re not familiar with them—you’ve emphasized that before.”

Duncan couldn’t hear any seriousness in her tone and could only sigh. “So how was it resolved in the end? I mean Lawrence’s ‘cargo list.’”

“Frostholm needs supplies now, and we never break a contract. Since the cargo has arrived, of course we have to pay,” Agatha said, then shook her head. “But we could only pay part of it.”

“Oh?”

“The most critical ‘cargo’, Anomaly 077 in runaway state, couldn’t be delivered,” Agatha explained. “The contract called for the White Oak to hand over ‘Sailor’ to Frostholm’s sacred relic Hall in a sealed state, not a lively, bouncing mummified corpse…

“Then again, that mummified corpse himself seemed very eager to be ‘delivered.’ When he heard that the cargo list for Frostholm included him, he almost cried with joy. Sadly, we have no idea how to deal with an Anomaly stuck in a long-term runaway state that can’t be sealed again. It’s better to hand him over to you to handle personally.”

“An Anomaly in a long-term runaway state, huh…”

Duncan muttered without thinking and turned his head to look beside him.

Alice turned her head too and found the captain looking at her. The doll girl’s face immediately lit up with delight. “Hehe…”

Duncan sighed. “All right, I do have some experience.”

Agatha also glanced at Alice without thinking, a somewhat complicated expression on her face.

By now, she had already learned from Duncan the true identity of this “doll girl.” As someone born and raised in Frostholm, she naturally knew how extraordinary it was for “Anomaly 099” to be strolling openly through the city.

She had countless questions she wanted to ask. Strong curiosity and a vague unease stirred in her chest, which had long since grown cold. Yet faced with

Captain Duncan, who seemed not to care about anything, she never found a chance to speak.

“I was thinking…”

Agatha seemed to have finally made up her mind and broke the silence. But just as she was about to ask something about Alice, a sudden jolt of dread made her stop short.

At almost the same moment, everyone in the group halted.

Agatha turned her head and looked toward the deepest point of the long, deep tunnel. Under the thick black cloth, her sight, which had already been sublimated in the flames, shook, trembled, and twisted. It was as if invisible winds were blowing straight toward her, and countless chaotic voices were mixed in those unseen gusts, battering her senses.

She felt her mind being disturbed. Some vast presence in the depths of the tunnel—no, strictly speaking, the echo left behind by some vast presence—was resonating with her reason. She could not “see” what was there, but she could feel that within that immense, tangled echo, there was a faint response.

That faint response was softly calling her over.

“What’s… over there?”

The blind Goddess official spoke, reaching out without thinking as if to steady her slightly shaking body.

A hand reached out from the side, a little large but clearly with feminine lines—Vanna took Agatha by the arm and lifted her gaze to the vast darkness at the end of the tunnel.

“It looks like a hollow,” Vanna said softly, her voice carrying a bit of tension. “A huge… hollow.”

Chapter 450: Boiling Gold

A huge void lay at the end of the tunnel.

Vanna reached the edge of the void. The tunnel ended abruptly here. The floor and ceiling seemed to have been swallowed by some invisible thing and vanished ahead. Beyond the neat broken edge, the vast, empty darkness pressed down even on her, an Inquisitor. The instinctive fear Humans felt when facing such an enormous dark space surged over her like a tidal wave.

Morris also came to the “entrance” of the void. He raised his consecrated lantern, but the light from the special underground lantern seemed to be swallowed at once. The light did not really disappear. The space ahead was simply too huge, and there was nothing in any direction for it to reflect off. The lantern’s glow weakened in the dark and finally only lit a steep slope running down along the pit wall. Everything else stayed buried in darkness.

“This… there is no way this was part of the original mine, no matter how you look at it,” Vanna said softly. She took a shallow breath and looked back at the mine passage they had walked along. “The normal tunnel ends here… This should be the ‘stone wall’ mentioned in the report.”

Morris bent down and carefully examined the small section of inner wall that the consecrated lantern could reach. “It feels as if some huge ‘thing’ once filled this place,” he said slowly. “Now that thing has vanished into thin air, and it left a big hole behind.”

“A hollow this big didn’t collapse but actually settled?” Duncan could not help frowning. He looked up into the darkness above with a worried tone.

“If this place gives way, at least a third of the Upper City will be in serious trouble.”

As he said this, he suddenly turned his head and glanced at Agatha. “Are you alright? You haven’t seemed right for a while.”

“I… can’t see the ‘void’ you’re talking about,” Agatha said, her voice a bit uncertain. “I only see huge, twisted echoes coiled here. The wind is full of noise. Is there really nothing in front of us?”

“Nothing at all, at least to the eye. And I can’t sense any corruption left by supernatural power either,” Vanna said with a firm nod. Then she grew thoughtful. “But you can feel something… Maybe what’s left here is resonating with you?”

“I don’t know.” Agatha shook her head, then turned toward Duncan. “What do you think?”

“We should go in and see what it’s like inside.” Duncan had already made up his mind. He raised his hand and beckoned in the air. A clump of ghostly green flame appeared out of thin air beside him. A skeletal bird wrapped in roaring flame burst out of the fire, flapped its wings, and landed on his shoulder as if it knew the way by heart.

Ai tilted her head and looked around. “Your experienced guide is here! Your experienced guide is here!”

“We can’t rule out the risk that this ‘cave’ might collapse, so we’ll bring this pigeon,” Duncan explained. “Once we go in, don’t split up. Watch the surroundings at all times for any sign of instability. Pay attention to the sounds above our heads. At the first sign of a cave-in, everyone teleportation.”

“Yes, Captain.” “Understood.” “Okay.” “Hehe…”

Duncan gave Alice a light tap on the head, then checked the terrain at the edge of the void. He took a quiet breath and was the first to step out into the darkness.

The others followed close behind.

Past the edge of the void there was a steep slope. The slope was not continuous. Sudden drops and twisting side paths appeared at any time, so every step had to be taken with great care. This winding, difficult path stretched into the depths of the darkness, as if it could reach the very bottom of the hollow.

The slope felt like a deep groove left in the rock after some long-term corruption finally faded away.

Duncan moved forward carefully in the dark. ghostly green flame burned and spread around his feet. The steady spirit flame lit a small circle around the path and left a bright “trail of fire” behind them. When they looked back, they could see the line of flowing flame drawing a twisting road in the darkness that led back to the hollow’s entrance.

In such a vast underground dark space, marking the way was extremely important. Even with the Pigeon Spirit as their ultimate escape method, Duncan still left his own flames along the way out of caution. The flames also extended his senses, helping him notice any subtle change in the cave walls.

Vanna had already formed a greatsword of solid ice and storm in her hand. She held the sword in one hand and stayed alert for any Monster that might be hiding in the huge dark. Alice walked the whole way with both hands carefully holding her own head, afraid that if she slipped, she might lose it in the dark. Agatha’s senses were disturbed by some “echo” in this cave, so she could only walk with Vanna’s help, taking careful steps on the rough slope.

Morris, meanwhile, walked along curiously studying the stones by the path.

“Very dense rock… and it seems fused and squeezed together,” he said. He lifted the consecrated lantern, silver light flickering in his eyes as he tried to see as far as he could. “If the whole cave wall is made of this kind of layer, it might explain why the structure could stay stable after its ‘contents’ vanished. These rocks form a dense, thick ‘inner shell’ that supports the whole thing.”

He hesitated, then added in an unsure voice, “But an inner shell alone may still not be enough. For a cavity this large, there should be other supports in the middle.”

Vanna could not help glancing at the Old Gentleman. “Just how many fields do you know?”

“Mathematics, history, chemistry, occult studies, physics, a little geology and mining, and some knowledge about fighting, firearms, machinery, and blasting,” Morris answered offhand. “Is there a problem?”

Vanna stared, stunned. “How… did you manage that?”

“Just read more books in your spare time,” Morris said. “It isn’t strange that I know these things. I am, after all, the Historian.”

Vanna looked at Morris with a strange expression. In her heart she complained that, except for firearms, fighting, and blasting, nothing he had just listed sounded like it had anything to do with the job of “the Historian”. But after thinking about it for a long time, she still did not have the nerve to say it out loud.

Agatha, leaning on Vanna’s arm, looked even stranger. As a Gatekeeper, she was once again deeply shaken by the followers around Captain Duncan. The last time she had felt this way was when she learned that Vanna was the Athlete…

Morris himself clearly did not realize he had amazed everyone. His attention was already back on the “stones” under his feet.

In the overlapping light of the consecrated lantern and the green flame, the surface of the stones showed a faint metallic sheen. And whether it was an illusion or not… there also seemed to be special lines on their surface.

The Old Scholar bent down, picked up a piece of broken stone, and examined it with interest.

He suddenly stopped walking.

Duncan stopped as well and looked curiously at the stone in Morris’s hand. “Is something wrong?”

Several seconds passed before Morris suddenly seemed to come back to himself. He spoke in a strange, shaken tone. “…It’s Boiling Gold.”

Agatha immediately turned her head. “Boiling Gold?”

“Boiling Gold ore, almost pure enough to feed straight into a steam-core reactor boiler…” Morris muttered in shock. Then he quickly bent down and picked up another piece. After checking it, he simply squatted and carefully examined every stone at his feet. The more he checked, the more alarmed he became. “Here too… No wonder, no wonder I thought the texture of these ‘stones’ was strange just now. It was just too dark to see…”

The Old Scholar suddenly stopped, then raised his head to look at Duncan and Agatha.

His face showed stunned disbelief and a faint excitement that came with a great discovery. “It really is Boiling Gold, Captain, Agatha—this entire cave is made of Boiling Gold! At least the pit floor is covered in raw ore!”

Everyone fell silent. In that silence, Duncan clearly felt Agatha’s emotions surging. Vanna even felt Agatha’s body trembling slightly.

No one understood the meaning of Boiling Gold better than someone born in Frostholm.

“This is all Boiling Gold. We already saw remaining Boiling Gold veins in the tunnels,” Vanna whispered, holding Agatha’s hand. “It looks like Frostholm doesn’t need to worry too much, at least for a while.”

“Yes… we don’t need to worry… there is still Boiling Gold here…” Agatha murmured. Her tone was strangely mixed. “But why? Why are these things here…”

“Would the corruption of the Abyssal Lord leave Boiling Gold behind?” Duncan frowned. “If our information is right, this Great Hollow was formed that way…”

Everyone suddenly grew serious. Even Alice, who was always slow to pick up on things, felt the change in the air. The doll girl edged close and tugged on Duncan’s arm, then asked carefully, “Captain… what is Boiling Gold?”

Duncan: “…”

With everyone so serious, it really took some talent for this fool to stay such a steady, unwavering fool.

He sighed. “Boiling Gold is the base of modern industry. It’s the energy source for all steam-powered machines. Just like people need food, machines need Boiling Gold to run.”

Alice listened, half understanding. After a long moment, she finally nodded in sudden realization. “Oh—”

Duncan did not worry about whether this illiterate doll had really understood. His gaze turned again toward the darkness ahead.

The huge underground hollow had stirred his curiosity completely.

If this whole cave was made of extremely pure Boiling Gold… then what would be waiting for him at its deepest point?

Chapter 451: History in the Mist and Mist in the History

The group moved forward in the dark. The ghostly flame became a glowing path, tracing the marks of their way deeper into the cave. The light of the consecrated lantern and the spirit flame shone on the road ahead so they could just barely see what surrounded them.

Along the way, what Duncan's group saw most often was Boiling Gold.

High-purity Boiling Gold made up every part of the cave's terrain. Layer upon layer of dense rock formed a strong shell, and a huge amount of loose ore lay scattered across the pit floor, impossible to count.

These ores were the base of modern industry, the lifeblood of Frostholm. Yet seeing them here only made the atmosphere grow more and more strange.

But Duncan did not care much about that strangeness. He was a practical man. Elder Gods or no Elder Gods came second. If Boiling Gold could be used, then it was good. Even if this Boiling Gold really was a "product" of the Abyssal Lord, he did not mind using it.

In fact, if he were the city-state's Governor, the only thing he would be thinking about right now would be how feasible it was to open a branch mine in the Abyssal Deep, in the Deep Sea, and how to draw up a plan for sustainable mining on the Abyssal Lord.

But he did not say any of this out loud.

For an ordinary person like Agatha, that kind of development idea might be a bit extreme.

Duncan's mind turned with all sorts of thoughts, but then a hazy patch of Shadows at the edge of his sight made him suddenly stop.

The others stopped as well. Morris seemed to see something too. He raised the consecrated lantern to light the area and said: "There seems to be something ahead."

In the limited glow from the consecrated lantern and the spirit flame, a huge mass of Shadows slowly appeared in the endless darkness. It looked like a pillar standing in the distance, or the trunk of a towering tree. Its upper half spread out in a vague way, as if some branching structure reached up into the dark.

Even though she could not see it clearly, the dim outline alone let Agatha feel its enormous size. It was like a giant column that could hold up a whole mountain. Even across a great distance, it gave off a heavy sense of pressure.

Vanna tightened her grip on her greatsword and warned everyone: "Move forward carefully."

The group continued on through the dark. As they drew closer, that vague patch of Shadows slowly became clearer before them.

A huge "pillar", like the tower of the Cathedral, stood in the center of the Great Hollow. In the lantern light, it showed itself in a breathtaking way.

"Eye of Wisdom…"

Morris gasped without thinking, and the consecrated lantern in his hand even shook. He stared at the pillar. Its black surface was uneven and rough, like the tentacle of some Deep Sea creature grown countless times larger. Its lower half was buried deep in the ground, surrounded by wrinkled, broken

rock, as if it had grown from the seawater under the city and stabbed straight through the island's base. Its upper half ran up into the endless darkness overhead and split into faint branches there, like a strange giant tree that had twisted and grown in this unknown deep, then quietly died.

It was so massive that the lantern's glow could not possibly light the whole pillar. It was hard even to light a small part of its front. Morris could see only the patch of rough surface where the lantern light reached. The larger, hazier structures were picked out by the dim green flame spreading around them. As for the parts even the green flame could not reach… there he could only rely on his imagination, trying to make sense of the very blurred Shadows.

Even the usually careless doll girl felt deeply shaken by the sight.

Alice tilted her head back, then grabbed her head with both hands and pulled hard. With a soft pop, she pulled her head off. She lifted her own head high and tried her best to look up, but still could not see clearly, so she tossed her head upward a few times. After throwing it several times, she finally felt for it and pressed it back onto her neck, then kept staring up in a daze. "Wow…"

Vanna turned to look at Alice. "…Wow."

"What is this thing?" Morris's full attention was on the pillar, both grand and terrifying. He could not help taking a couple of steps forward and carefully touching its pitted surface. The cold, rough feel under his fingers was like rock. "It feels like stone, but it looks like some kind of…"

"Some huge limb," Duncan said. He tilted his head back to look up at the upper half of the pillar. After a few seconds he spoke softly. "It seems to be what's holding up the whole cave."

“So this is the real reason the cave hasn’t collapsed…” Morris murmured. He leaned close to the pillar and studied its surface by the lantern’s glow. “Judging from the lines, this also looks a bit like Boiling Gold ore, but it’s not quite like any ore the books describe… It seems mixed with impurities.”

“If we guess boldly, maybe this is a piece of the Abyssal Lord’s limb,” Duncan said casually. “It stretched into the city and was burned into stone here.”

The scene fell silent for a moment. Several seconds passed before Vanna finally twitched the corner of her mouth and broke the silence. “That sounds a bit scary…”

“Scary, but very likely. I only added ‘maybe’ for your sake,” Duncan said, shaking his head. “Don’t forget, my flame once spread here. Things were chaotic back then, so I didn’t have time to sense everything in detail, but I remember… whatever was here was very hard to burn.”

As he spoke, he stepped forward and reached out to touch the pillar’s rough, rock-like surface.

On the other side, Agatha also felt her way toward the “pillar”.

In her “vision”, everything was still shaking under the interference of some resonant force. This empty cave became, in her eyes, a strange place full of chaotic ripples. Yet even in that endless interference, she could clearly “see” the “pillar” before her.

A faint pull drove her closer.

Agatha carefully reached out and stroked the pillar. Her fingers moved over the cold surface as if she were flipping through a book carved from stone, reading the memories left inside the rock.

Some depressions caught her attention.

She traced them, drawing their shapes in her mind. She placed her palm in one of the hollows and found that each of her fingers fit into it perfectly.

It was a handprint.

After a brief shock, she reached out with her other hand. Guided by a sudden, baseless instinct in her mind, she groped around and found another handprint.

It felt as if a trace of fine ash still remained inside the print.

Agatha suddenly froze. She instinctively wanted to turn her head and tell Duncan what she had found. But in the next second, countless tangled lights and shadows rose all at once in her dark, chaotic vision.

Memories rose in her heart. Thin but real emotions were mixed among them. Countless pieces of information flooded into her mind. It was as if those messages had been sleeping in Agatha's head from the very start, as if they were her own experiences. At the moment she touched those two handprints, they suddenly woke up inside her!

A search in the dark… A meeting with Governor Winston's echo… The true nature of the Abyssal Trench Project… The preparations made by each generation of Governor… The power of the Elder Gods invading the city, the thoughts of the Elder Gods drifting between illusion and the Mortal Realm, and…

This was a replica.

"Ah—"

Agatha gave a small cry. Her foot slipped, and she almost fell.

A hand reached out from the side and caught her in time. Duncan's voice sounded in the darkness. "What's wrong?"

Agatha blinked in a daze, then finally came back to herself. At once she became aware of the fragments that had appeared in her mind. She quickly stood steady and spoke fast: “I touched some memories… They were left by ‘her’!”

“Left by ‘her’?” Duncan frowned, understanding at once what she meant. “That replicant? Her memories remained here?”

“Yes. Listen, it’s important—she met Governor Winston here and learned the truth about the Abyssal Trench Project…”

Agatha spoke so fast it was as if she was afraid she would forget those fragments of memory in the next second. She almost did not pause as she poured out everything she had just seen and heard. She did not care whether the others had time to react. From the Governor’s last words to the source of Frostholm’s Queen’s obsession back then, and in the end, the strongest thought of all—the most stubborn idea “she” had left behind before vanishing.

The key message “she” wanted to pass on—the “Elder God” invading the city-state of Frostholm was a replica.

It was the replica of the Abyssal Lord.

Everyone fell silent. No matter how strange or terrifying Agatha’s tale sounded, no one interrupted her.

Only when Agatha said the last word did the scene fall quiet for another ten seconds or so. Morris was the first to break the silence.

“…History in the mist, and mist in the history…”

The Old Scholar could not help sighing.

Beside him, Duncan’s gaze had already fallen on the great “pillar”.

His eyes were more serious than they had ever been.

Chapter 452: Everything Is Permitted

Half a century ago, the Frostholm Queen's Abyssal Trench Project had been launched to find and solve the problem of Boiling Gold under the city-state.

Generations of Governors had inherited secrets about the Boiling Gold, the Queen, The curse, the Elder Gods in The Deep Sea, and the power of the Abyssal Lord, which had formed a real projection inside the city-state and bored out this huge hollow region beneath it…

Every one of these pieces of information was shocking.

But for Duncan, even all of that together was not as shocking as one fact: that the Elder Gods who had invaded the city-state were replicas.

Vanna realized the weight of that line too. As an Inquisitor who dealt with heretics and malevolent spirits for a living, her expression was unusually serious. She turned her gaze to the "giant pillar" that held up the cavern. Only after a long moment did she speak:

"First of all, this thing really is a remaining part of the 'Elder Gods' that invaded the city-state… And its source is still down in The Deep Sea beneath the city. So what Agatha just said about this 'replica' actually has two explanations."

"Yes, two explanations," Duncan nodded. "The first is that the 'source' on the sea floor is the real one. In that case, the corrupted mass it projected into the city-state can, in a sense, be seen as a replica, a copy.

“The second explanation…”

He paused, looked up at the giant pillar that supported the whole cave, then let out a breath.

“The second explanation is that the ‘source’ on the sea floor is also a replica. The other Agatha, in her final moment, touched not only the Elder God tendril in this cavern. Through that tendril, she also learned the truth in The Deep Sea. But time was short, and she had no chance to leave more explanation.”

The place went quiet for a while.

Alice lifted her head. Her curious gaze swept over everyone. She had not fully understood what they were talking about, but she was trying very hard to listen and make sense of it. After a long time, she tugged on Duncan’s arm:

“It sounds kind of scary?”

“Yes. And it’s hard to say whether the first possibility is scarier or the second,” Duncan answered. Even as he said “scarier,” there was a faint smile in his eyes. He rubbed Alice’s hair, comforting the doll who clearly did not understand but was already nervous: “You don’t need to worry so much. This won’t be more trouble than mirror world Frostholm.”

“Yes, it won’t be more trouble than mirror world Frostholm—as long as we don’t let that ‘source’ at the bottom of the sea keep growing,” Agatha said. She turned her head to “look” into Duncan’s eyes. “Just like you said last time, we still need to investigate under Frostholm again. We have to see whether the ‘Elder Gods’ that invaded the Mortal Realm are still there…”

Duncan gave a soft “mm.” He knew Agatha had not been idle and had surely already started preparing for this, so he did not press her. But just then, something flickered at the edge of his vision.

Something glowing flashed in Agatha’s right hand. It seemed to be a piece of metal.

“Agatha, what do you have in your hand?”

“In my hand?” Agatha was startled. She lifted her hand without thinking, and only then did she suddenly feel the foreign object in her palm—cold metal, yet already warmed a little by her body heat.

It was a strangely shaped brass key.

“The key…” Vanna stared at it in surprise, then suddenly understood. “Ah, this is the one you mentioned—the key that Governor Winston passed to the other ‘Agatha’ in the end? The key the Frostholm Queen left behind?”

Duncan’s eyes changed a little: “Let me see it.”

“Of course.” Agatha did not hesitate. She at once placed the key into Duncan’s hand.

The key was cast from brass. The handle was a thick “infinity” symbol, and the front end had no teeth. Instead, it was a round bar with grooves, like… the wind-up key used to wind a doll.

Alice leaned in close, hanging off Duncan’s arm: “Let me see, let me see… Huh? This is the key? It doesn’t look like the keys I’ve seen… What is it for?”

No one answered.

Every gaze landed on the doll, on Miss Doll herself.

“Why are you all looking at me?” Alice finally realized, pointed at herself, and asked: “Did I mess something up again?”

“When you look at this key, don’t you feel anything special?” Duncan lowered his head and looked into Alice’s eyes. “Like a sense of familiarity,

or a strong urge to touch it?”

“No…” Alice shook her head, completely lost. “I’ve never seen it before.”

Vanna leaned closer and whispered into Duncan’s ear: “Captain, do you think…”

“I remember Nina mentioned,” Duncan said slowly, “that there is a keyhole on Alice’s back.”

At that, Agatha “looked” toward the doll nearby—the doll created by Brother.

In that instant, it felt as if everything connected. Points scattered across time and space linked into crooked lines inside this cavern that had once been corrupted by an Elder God.

The key left by the Frostholm Queen, and the doll “Anomaly 099,” whose face was exactly the same as the Frostholm Queen’s, were the two end points of that line.

Yet under everyone’s gaze, Alice simply looked left and right in confusion. Then she raised her arm and tried hard to feel around her back.

“I can’t reach it,” she said, a little wronged and a little apologetic. “My clothes are in the way.”

“We’ll talk about it when we get back. This… needs caution,” Duncan said in a low voice, breaking the heavy mood in the cavern. Then he raised his head again and looked at Agatha. “I want to take this key with me. Is that all right?”

“Technically… this key is a legacy passed down by the Frostholm Governors. And according to Governor Winston, it also holds the ‘information’ the Frostholm Queen left behind. But…”

Agatha paused, then gently shook her head.

“It’s all in the past now. Of course you can take it.”

“Thank you.” Duncan did not stand on ceremony. He put the key into the beak of the pigeon resting on his shoulder. With a flash of eerie green flame, Ai and the key vanished from his shoulder together. A second later, the pigeon returned, but the key was gone.

It had already been sent to the ship, into the hands of Duncan’s true body.

On the Vanished, Duncan turned the newly delivered key over in his fingers. In the hollow underground space beneath Frostholm, Duncan turned back to look once more at the giant pillar that held up the cavern and knocked lightly on its hard, icy stone surface.

“We should leave,” he said.

The cavern was huge. Even with the flames of spirit form to help, the area the group had explored so far was only a small part of the hollow. But for Duncan, the information gathered here was already enough.

He needed time to slowly sort out and digest what he had gained. Follow-up exploration… could be left to Agatha and Agatha’s subordinates.

After confirming that no Elder God corruption remained in the cavern and that the cavern itself had a stable supporting structure, Agatha could now feel relatively safe bringing her subordinates here.

Following the path marked by spirit flame, the group safely withdrew from the vast hollow. Then they boarded the shaft lift and returned to the mine tunnels above.

On the way out of the Boiling Gold mine, Duncan asked Agatha, curious: “What are your thoughts about that hollow below?”

“My thoughts?” Agatha thought for a moment. “I’ll probably lead a few more expeditions. At least enough to understand the surface of the cavern

and the area around that huge pillar. If we find anything valuable in the process, I'll share it with you at once. As for after that…"

She stopped there, as if she were thinking very carefully, and only then said slowly: "After that, I'll suggest that the city-state find a way to mine the Boiling Gold in the cavern. Under the condition that we avoid a collapse of the hollow and avoid damaging that 'pillar', we should try to bring that Boiling Gold out. Of course, how to actually do that is up to the professionals in City Hall."

"You're not worried about the 'hidden danger' in that Boiling Gold?" Duncan asked casually. "After all, it might be something the Elder Gods left behind."

"…The city-state has to stay alive first. Only then can we think about anything else," Agatha said with a small shake of her head. "And after I 'saw' what was inside that cavern, I thought of something."

"Oh?"

"If the Boiling Gold under Frostholm is something left behind after the Elder Gods' power drilled through, then what about the other city-states on The Boundless Sea? Are we really sure that nothing is wrong under any city-state's foundations?"

The group fell silent again.

"After the ore veins from the Queen's era ran dry, Frostholm spent another fifty years mining Boiling Gold from the mirror world world," Agatha went on. "We instinctively believed that Boiling Gold mined from the mirror world world, like everything else from there, was just a replica. But after the mirror world city-state was destroyed, the Boiling Gold did not disappear. It even left behind a new 'rich deposit' in the underground cavern we just found…

“The only possible explanation is that Boiling Gold created by the power of the Elder Gods is not a ‘distortion’.”

“If Boiling Gold created by the Elder Gods isn’t distortion, then it can only be a natural part of the world,” Duncan said, his tone thoughtful. “That already sounds close to the Annihilators’ ‘Holy Lord created the world’ theory.”

“Yes. It already counts as something heretical,” Agatha admitted, calm and open.

“But you don’t look shaken.”

Agatha stopped walking. She slowly raised her head. Her gaze seemed to pass through the black band over her eyes and rest quietly ahead.

At the end of the passage was the mine’s surface exit. Bright sunlight poured in from there, warm and clear.

In Agatha’s perception, the entire world was still very cold, as cold as a tomb.

But she knew that sunlight was warm.

“Just like I said earlier, the city-state has to survive first,” this devout priestess of the Goddess said softly. She folded her hands over her chest as if in prayer. “There is only one kind of heretic in this world: anyone who hinders our survival is a heretic. Besides that, everything is permitted.”

Chapter 453: Pointing to the God

The whirlwind, wrapped around pale dust, slowly faded from Duncan's sight.

Agatha had left.

"I keep feeling… she's changed a lot compared to before," Vanna finally broke the silence only after the last strand of Ashen Wind vanished into the air. "Especially those last words she said. That's nothing like what the old 'Gatekeeper' would have said."

"Experience changes a person, especially everything she has gone through," Duncan said calmly. "And besides, the role she carries now is more than just 'Gatekeeper'. That means she is bound to change."

Vanna sounded a bit curious: "You don't seem worried?"

"Because she hasn't wavered. People who have truly seen through things often end up more firm," Duncan said offhandedly. "She is rational. She won't take some extreme or wrong path just because of the city-state's survival pressure. Her last few sentences might not sound very pious, but at least she is very clear-headed."

Vanna did not answer for a moment. Duncan turned his head and looked at the young Inquisitor with quiet meaning: "The one you're worried about isn't really Agatha, is it?"

"…My faith doesn't allow me to lie," Vanna said at last, after a brief silence and a soft sigh. "Yes, I'm worried about my own state. In Agatha, I see

myself—the same shaken faith, the same rebellious words and actions."

Duncan stayed quiet and simply waited for her to go on.

"…I once believed that, as long as I kept firm faith and unwavering courage, I could face and solve any problem," Vanna said. "The deity laid down the order by which the world runs. We were like gears, just turning peacefully in the frame.

"But the truth is… that order was as fragile as bubbles on the sea. Pure faith and courage cannot save our city-state. The understanding of the world that we built up over so many years is being tested…

"'The Sun' is not eternal. The 'Boiling Gold' that supports modern civilization might be a product of the Elder Gods. The gods cannot always shelter the city-states. Beneath The Deep Sea lies an unknown darkness that no religious scripture has ever described or explained—and your appearance has overturned my understanding of Subspace from the last twenty-plus years."

"As for that last point, I suggest you hold back a bit on drawing conclusions—but the other things you said are fine," Duncan said, shaking his head, his tone unhurried. "Human understanding of the world is partial by nature. From the start, we shouldn't assume there's some simple and eternal 'logic' that can roughly explain all things.

"Maybe such a simple and eternal 'Truth' really does exist, but it's not something humans at this stage can understand. On that basis, having your worldview overturned is a necessary step in the progress of civilization."

Listening to Duncan, Vanna slipped into thought. Her expression grew more and more complicated. After a moment, she spoke almost to herself: "Then where do the gods stand?"

“I don’t know, because I haven’t dealt with them directly,” Duncan said openly. “Maybe I’ve seen them from far away, but that isn’t enough for me to judge them.

“But I admit two things. First, the Four Gods really do exist in this world, at least as objective beings. Second… up to now, they have, to some degree, protected and guided the civilized world.”

Vanna looked stunned. In over twenty years of life, this was the first time she had heard someone talk about the Four Gods in such a way—without any trace of good or evil, fear or worship, as if simply judging an object.

That way of describing them held no reverence at all. It was almost arrogance.

Yet when those words came from a being who had returned from Subspace, Vanna only felt…

Those words were cold and accurate, like a ruler used to measure the world.

Just then, Duncan’s voice broke through Vanna’s thoughts: “Vanna, don’t think too much. You still believe in Gamona, don’t you?”

“Yes. My faith is unchanged,” Vanna answered at once.

“That’s right. Your faith is unchanged. Agatha also still believes in Bartok. And neither of your deities has abandoned you because your thoughts have changed. Their divine blessing is still there. That means your thinking right now hasn’t gone against them,” Duncan said seriously. “Thinking doesn’t necessarily lead to heresy, and neither does doubt.

“To think and to doubt, then still choose to believe—that is a true devout believer.

“Keep a proper and healthy faith, and also keep a proper and healthy doubt. Try to understand this world. Accept that it’s not what you imagined.

Accept the narrowness and bias in your own understanding. Accept your own wavering.

“To be honest, if Gamona can accept your prayers to her on the Vanished, what else can’t you accept?”

Vanna started, then unconsciously raised her head. She looked toward the Upper City, toward the silent grand cathedral at the highest point of Frostholm.

By now, Agatha had likely already returned to that temple on the Ashen Wind. Would she go back to her prayer room and, before Bartok’s statue, keep thinking about the cooperation she had reached with the Subspace Shadows?

Would she keep thinking about the city-state’s future and again draw the conclusion that “anyone who hinders survival is a heretic; besides that, everything is permitted”?

After a long time, Vanna withdrew her gaze from the distance and murmured: “…The Lord doesn’t mind?”

“I don’t know. But if it were me, I wouldn’t mind,” Duncan said with a shrug. “And from what we’ve seen so far, the God of Death and the Storm Goddess don’t seem to mind either. They may care about something else.”

Vanna fell back into thought. Beside her, Morris, who had not spoken this whole time, could not help but sigh softly: “I didn’t expect you to have such deep thoughts about faith… I thought you weren’t interested in these things.”

“How could that be? I’ve always been interested in any theory that tries to explain this world,” Duncan said, his expression very serious. “For example, right now, I’m going to study another ‘faith’ that tries to explain the world.”

Seeing the confused looks on Vanna and Morris's faces (Alice was an exception, since she had never understood in the first place), Duncan smiled: "We don't need to worry about the city-state for now. Next, it's about time we went to look at that 'Blasphemous Tome'."

…

Shirley had fallen asleep—while she was working on the fourth math card.

The chains gave a small clink in the cabin. Dog carefully held the black chain with one paw as it raised its upper body. With its mouth, it picked up a blanket and draped it over Shirley. With its other paw, it casually pushed around the math cards on the table so they wouldn't get soaked by Shirley's drool.

As Dog straightened things, its gaze swept over the cards filled with simple addition, subtraction, multiplication, and division. Its movements paused: "…She actually got most of them right?"

Dog muttered in surprise, then turned its head without thinking. It saw Shirley shift her position in her sleep, mumbling some dream-words, a shiny line of drool hanging from the corner of her mouth.

"…I guess she did take them seriously," Dog said to itself.

Dog shook its head and lay down again. Then it steadied itself, as if after a long hesitation and weighing of choices, and stretched out a paw to drag a book from its own pile on the floor.

The cover was plain—just a paperback textbook you could buy in any city-state. On the front were the words "Algebraic Calculations".

Dog lowered its head. The blood-red glow in its eye sockets flickered as it stared quietly at the book in front of its paw. After a long time, it slowly opened the cover.

But right after that, Dog suddenly jerked its head up and quickly scanned the room.

Everything on the bookshelf looked normal. The shaded corners of the room were calm. sunlight streamed through the window into the cabin. From outside came the soft, gentle sound of the waves.

“…All right. The environment is safe. Distractions cleared. The book is still math… Try again… Third test.”

Dog muttered, then finally lowered its head and began to read the book with full focus.

It tried to understand the formulas, remember the symbols, work through the numbers. From the knowledge and wisdom of those who came before, Dog tried to understand how the world worked.

At first it was hard. Stray thoughts and awareness of the room kept disturbing the process of thinking. But soon Dog’s mind grew quiet. As always, math helped it concentrate and sink into thought.

Symbols and numbers combined in its mind. Its understanding of the world slowly filled its head. Dog studied with full attention, and gradually, it felt as if something appeared in its mind…

A study partner.

Someone was reading with it.

Someone was thinking with it.

Some presence was watching this place with curiosity—a gaze that held neither good nor evil.

Dog tilted its head.

Under the white pages of the book, in the gaps between the words, inside the city of knowledge traced out by symbols and lines, a red light was surrounded by countless flickering, matrix-like points of light, like an eye staring at Dog.

Dog froze.

It stared back at the red light.

It could not help staring at that red light.

It even felt itself leaning forward—actively drawing closer to that flickering matrix of light.

But that feeling lasted only an instant.

The next second, a force suddenly surged from the symbiotic pact chain and yanked Dog back, tearing it free from that strange pull.

"…What the heck…"

Dog cried out, snapping awake from the brief vision. The next second, it instinctively looked at the black chain on its neck.

At the last moment, the power from that chain had dragged it back—clearly, Shirley had given it a pull.

But the chain still lay loose on the floor, not tight at all.

On the other end of the chain, Shirley was still sprawled over the desk, dead asleep.

She had not woken up at all.

Chapter 454: Flow of Information

Ghostly green flame rose in the captain's cabin. The skeletal bird wrapped in spirit flame flew out of the fire, and the whirling flames behind it formed a doorway like a vortex. When the door opened, Vanna, Alice, and Morris stepped out into the cabin.

As the dizziness from the shift of light and shadow faded, they turned toward the nearby chart table and bowed to Duncan, who sat behind it studying the enchanted sea chart: "Captain."

"Find a place to sit and rest first. It's easy to fall if you walk right after teleportation," Duncan said without looking up. He checked a few more points on the enchanted sea chart, then let out a small breath and straightened to look at Morris: "You brought the book?"

"Yes," Morris nodded quickly. He reached inside his coat and took out the book with the pitch-black, titleless cover, the Blasphemous Tome, then got up and handed it to Duncan: "Here it is."

Duncan reached out and took the book. Beside him, Vanna could not help speaking: "Now that Morris, Alice, and I have all returned to the ship, only your avatar form is left in the city-state… is that alright?"

"There won't be any big trouble in the city anymore. Tyrian will become Frostholm's new Governor, and with him and Agatha maintaining order, there is nothing to worry about," Duncan said with a smile. "As far as you three are concerned, your work in Frostholm is done. Any follow-up can be handled by my avatar form."

As he spoke, Duncan sat back down behind the chart table with the heavy Black Leather Tome in his hand. He set it beside the enchanted sea chart, and his expression grew solemn.

This was the Blasphemous Tome that Morris and Vanna had taken from the low-ranking leader of the Annihilators. It contained records about the Abyssal Lord and seemed to mention certain secrets from before the Gods created the world and before the time node of the Great Annihilation.

From the outside, the book looked ordinary. Aside from its pitch-black, titleless cover, there was nothing special about it, and no hint of any supernatural aura seeped from it.

Vanna, Morris, and Alice had already crowded over in curiosity. Except for carefree Alice, the other two still kept a cautious distance and did not dare look straight at the book.

The Goathead wood carving at the edge of the chart table creaked as it turned its neck. It twisted its head toward the big book in front of Duncan, stared for a long time, then finally could not help speaking: “What is this thing? A book? Is it really worth such solemn treatment?”

“In theory, it’s a missionary manuscript copied by Annihilators,” Duncan said casually. “It seems to contain things related to the Gods creating the world. Most of it is those cultists’ mad theories, but part of it… concerns me.”

“Records of the Gods creating the world?” Goathead froze for a moment, and his tone changed subtly: “Those madmen’s ‘Genesis Protocol of the Abyssal Lord’? With all due respect, their theories are worthless in my eyes. If someone can invent an entire history of the world’s birth without solid evidence or reasoning, then any drunk playwright could explain the foundations of our world. There is even an absurd play that claims this world was stewed out of a great pot of hotchpotch…”

“But when Morris read this book, his mind suffered corruption, and it even drew the attention of the Four Gods,” Duncan said slowly as he lifted his eyelids. “You should know what that means.”

A sharp crack sounded from the base of Goathead’s neck, and he stayed silent for a long moment.

After who knew how long, he finally squeezed out a sentence: “The closer you get to the Truth, the farther you are from sanity…”

“Yes. The first rule of Anomaly and Visions is: the closer you get to the Truth, the farther you are from sanity,” Morris said gravely, nodding. “The more easily an item causes severe mental corruption, the more likely it is that it records the world’s true form. So sometimes scholars even judge the reliability of old scrolls by how damaged their minds feel after reading them.”

Goathead swayed his head where he stood. After thinking for a long time, he still could not hold back: “But massive distortion and pure higher-order supernatural power can cause mental corruption too. In that case, the truth points the other way—the more damaged a mind is, the more it has been deceived.”

He paused, then added: “I’m serious, Morris. Plenty of unfortunates in your line of work died because of this, and the ones who didn’t die all thought they had grasped the Truth when they hit their madness threshold. Most of them are now wanted as heretics on Church posters all over the place. Of course, now that you’ve boarded this ship, if we really want to be precise, you’re on those wanted lists too…”

Goathead’s style was strange, but after spending so long together it was clear he still had some genuine concern for the crew. His words sounded harsh, but the worry in them was real.

Morris knew this, so he did not mind. He spoke honestly to Goathead: “Thank you for the concern. You’re right. This world was very good at fooling mortals, and curiosity often led us the wrong way. That is why we need the captain to make the final call.”

“The captain will…” Goathead faltered, finally noticing that Duncan’s hand already rested on the cover of the Black Leather Tome and that he looked ready to open it. “Huh? Are you sure you want to read it?”

“What else would I do with it?” Duncan looked up. “Did you think I had Morris bring this thing aboard just to use it as your stand?”

Goathead stared blankly for a moment and wobbled his head from side to side: “Well… that wouldn’t be the worst idea…”

Duncan ignored his antics. He had already prepared himself. He drew in a deep breath, letting his mind slowly focus.

A ghostly green blaze rose from within him, and in an instant his body shifted into spirit form. After confirming that the transformation was complete, Duncan opened the first page of the Black Leather Tome.

At first glance, he saw no writing on the page.

At the second glance, he saw boundless darkness suddenly gather from all directions.

In an instant, the light and shadows shifted before he had time to react. Just like the first time he used the spirit compass of the Spirit Realm, Duncan’s consciousness suddenly plunged into a boundless darkness.

He lifted his head in startled confusion. Everything familiar in the captain’s cabin had disappeared. Goathead, Morris, and the others were gone, and even the Black Leather Tome he had been looking at a second earlier had vanished.

He stood in the darkness, frowning as he thought for a few seconds.

Something was wrong—this was not the process Morris had described.

After he opened the book, something completely different had happened compared to when Morris opened it!

Just then, something appeared at the edge of his vision.

Zhou Ming looked over on instinct. He saw tiny white light-shapes floating in midair not far from him. He focused, and finally realized… they were words.

The words became clear—

“After he opened the book, something completely different happened compared to when Morris opened it.”

Zhou Ming froze.

He stood motionless, his gaze fixed on the line of words hanging in the air. For a moment he even forgot to breathe, forgot to think.

Only after who knew how long did he suddenly remember something.

He remembered. He had seen a place like this before. He had once visited a darkness just like this and seen words within it—that had been in Subspace…

“It was in Subspace, aboard the broken Vanished sailing through Subspace. When I pushed open the door to the captain’s cabin, there was a dark place, and words appeared in the darkness, describing…”

Pale words flashed quickly in midair, then gradually faded.

Zhou Ming stopped suddenly. He forced himself to stop thinking wildly. It was very hard, but he stuffed his mind full of random numbers, words, and

meaningless scenery from his memories. At last, the words that had appeared in the darkness before him truly vanished.

Then he worked hard to rein in his thoughts and calm his pounding heart.

What on earth was going on? What was this darkness? What were these words that appeared from within it?

They seemed to be describing “himself”… but were they really describing “himself”? And what did this kind of “description” even mean?

Was this some kind of mind-reading process? Or a “reflection” phenomenon on the level of the soul? The last time he had seen a similar dark space had been on the broken Vanished in Subspace, but this time it had happened after opening the book—why did that book have this kind of “power”?

More thoughts rose uncontrollably in his mind, and almost at the same time, new words appeared in the darkness.

But this time, the words did not describe “himself”. They were a few fragments with no beginning or end—

“Manifest… transformation toward the Mortal Realm… the real…”

Zhou Ming frowned and moved closer to the new line of words without thinking. He reached out a finger to try touching them.

His finger passed straight through the phantoms, and only faint ripples spread through the darkness.

As the ripples trembled, he vaguely saw that there seemed to be more words hidden behind the ones he could see!

He hesitated for only a second before reaching out again, stirring those words that were like reflections on water. He widened the ripples, forcing

the overlapping symbols to show their true shapes and drawing the other information hidden deep in the darkness into his sight—

Suddenly, he saw several broken lines of text appear in the darkness. They trembled as they stretched downward and shifted.

“Transmission source – Leviathan Queen: the situation… is not optimistic. The Critical Threshold is accelerating…”

“Transmission source – King of Fire: any new records?”

“Transmission source – Bartok: bad news… Node feedback is blurry… suspect the Cluster Controller has begun to copy itself… or has fully entered runaway state…”

“…Source – LH-02: I have relevant information.”

“…Details?”

“…LH-02: observed an individual with Cluster Controller traits approaching. Suspect a mental mutation. Suspect it can communicate with me.”

“Transmission source – Leviathan Queen: astonishing intel! Follow-up?”

“Transmission source – LH-02: no follow-up.”

“Transmission source – Bartok: ?”

“Transmission source – LH-02: that suspicious individual sent a dog-head icon and left.”

Chapter 455: Thoughts and Tests

The ripples in the darkness slowly calmed. The pale words no longer appeared. No matter how Zhou Ming focused or searched through the darkness, he could no longer see that eerie “conversation”.

Yes, a conversation—without a doubt it had been a conversation. And it seemed… to be a conversation between the Gods.

At the very least, Zhou Ming recognized the name “Bartok”.

In the darkness, Zhou Ming stood quietly in place. He no longer tried to stir up new ripples but instead sank into long contemplation. An astonishing flood of information surged in his mind like a tide. Behind his seemingly calm thoughts hid deep shock and a tangled mess of ideas.

Was this a nasty joke? That was clearly unlikely.

Then had it really happened? If so, when had this conversation taken place? Was it a record of something that had happened long ago, or… was it going on right now, in some mysterious dimension? Were “They” talking at this very moment, and that conversation was being reflected into this dark and uncanny place?

Bartok was the name of the God of Death. That was beyond doubt. So what did the other names stand for? The most reasonable idea was that they all represented Gods. Then the King of Fire was very likely Tarrigan, the “Everburning Ember” worshiped by the Flamebearer faith… and Leviathan Queen? Was that the storm Goddess?

The storm Goddess's other name was "Leviathan Queen"?!

In the darkness, Zhou Ming slowly furrowed his brow. The strange title "Leviathan Queen" stirred all kinds of guesses and associations in his mind, but even more distracting than that was the fourth name—

Among those speaking with the Gods, one had the name "LH-02".

If the speakers he had just seen each stood for one of the Four Gods, then the last one could only be Rahm, who held the divine authority of wisdom and madness among the Four Gods.

Rahm's name… was "LH-02"?! That did not sound like a name at all. It sounded more like a code. A sequence that belonged to a machine!

Countless wild guesses surged up. Zhou Ming felt as if his brain were boiling and tumbling. He had to work hard to rein in his wandering thoughts so those guesses would not spiral into pure nonsense. Even while he tried to sort through that chaotic mess, he did not overlook the shocking information mentioned in the "conversation".

The situation was grim. The Critical Threshold was accelerating… The Cluster Controller had begun to copy itself or had already fully entered runaway state…

Just those two sentences were enough for Zhou Ming to smell the tense, heavy atmosphere. What situation were "They" referring to? The state of the mortal world? Then the Critical Threshold accelerating… did it mean that the collapse of some huge system was fast approaching?

Zhou Ming instantly recalled his last conversation with Agatha. Pland and Frostholm had both run into trouble one after another. Vision 001 had "malfunctioned". This string of events all felt like the "Precursor Phase" of a vast system breaking down again and again.

Then the Cluster Controller had begun to copy itself…

Zhou Ming’s expression suddenly hardened, and a sentence surfaced in his mind—

“This is a replica.”

In the darkness, he could not help taking a quiet breath. He glanced toward the spot where the words had appeared earlier, as if expecting more information to show up there.

Of course, nothing appeared.

Zhou Ming withdrew his gaze with a grave expression.

There were, of course, many more questions worth worrying about. He had seen only a few lines of conversation, but the information behind each one was astonishing. Even each speaker’s name was worth thinking about at length—for example, Rahm, Gamona, and Tarrigan had all used “aliases”, so why had Bartok, the God of Death, used his straightforward true name? In the last message, LH-02, who was likely Rahm the God of Wisdom, also mentioned a suspicious visitor and said that the other party “sent a dog-head and left”… what was that about?

Honestly, if the earlier lines had not held such huge amounts of information, Zhou Ming’s full attention would probably have been caught by that last “dog-head”.

But now, that jarring sentence only seemed a bit strange.

Just then, a faint noise suddenly came from the depths of the darkness, interrupting the storm in Zhou Ming’s mind.

It sounded like something quietly shattering. At first the sound was very faint, almost like an illusion, but in almost no time, the breaking noises grew clear and rapid. Countless broken streaks of light and shadow appeared in the dark space. The growing noise filled Zhou Ming’s mind. The entire dark space began to fall apart and shatter at high speed. Whirling

lights rose from all directions. The next second, he heard a booming explosion inside his head!

In the next second, a brief sense of weightlessness and vertigo yanked him back into the Mortal Realm. The feeling of sitting in a chair made Duncan snap his eyes open.

Raging flames filled his vision. The nameless Black Leather Tome in his hands was already burning fiercely!

Alice's startled cry came from the side: "It's on fire! Captain! The book is on fire!"

Duncan jolted in surprise and quickly pressed his hand onto the blazing flames, taking control of the fire in the blink of an eye. However, the book burned at an absurd speed. In just that blink, more than half of it turned to ash, and only a small pile of scattered pages remained on the table.

A dark red liquid like blood seeped from what was left of the book, soaking and rotting the pages. Frowning, Duncan flipped through the remaining sheets and found they had all turned into soft, pulpy clumps. They were clearly unreadable.

He raised his head, his expression a bit odd: "I don't think I did anything."

"Judging from what we saw… this book probably could not withstand your power," Morris said after hesitating for a few seconds. "This is a clear case of supernatural overload."

"Could not withstand my power?" Duncan frowned and muttered without thinking.

Was it really just his power it could not withstand? The book had just borne… probably not only his power.

Perhaps it had just served as a medium—a medium for something far beyond its own limits.

Duncan remembered the golden Sun mask he had obtained in Pland. Through that mask he had glimpsed the form of the true Sun god, and it had destroyed the mask.

Morris did not know what Duncan was thinking, but he noticed the captain's expression did not look good and could not help adding: "This book should only be a 'copy', an supernatural item duplicated from an 'original' using some special ritual. supernatural items like this really are fragile by nature…"

Duncan looked up: "So if we had the 'original', it might be able to withstand me… 'reading' it?"

Morris adjusted his blessed monocle: "…In theory."

Alice glanced left and right, then finally could not help coming closer: "Captain, did you see something just now? Why do you look so serious…?"

Duncan rubbed his brow. Everything he had seen in the darkness rose again in his mind, but just as he opened his mouth, he suddenly stopped himself from telling the truth.

For weaker mortals, much "information" was poisonous in itself.

"I saw some things—different from what Morris saw," he said slowly after weighing his words for a few seconds. "But I can't tell you the details. They might hurt you."

Vanna and Morris exchanged looks at once. The next second, the same tension and gravity appeared in both their eyes.

After a brief thought, Morris spoke: "Different from what I saw… so the book shows different content depending on who is reading it?"

“That may be the case, but it might also be that it only shows different content in front of ‘me’,” Duncan said thoughtfully. Then his tone held a hint of regret: “It’s a shame… I should have left the test for last. Even letting Tyrian take a look at the contents first would have given us more clues. Now the only ‘sample’ is burned.”

Morris’s expression turned a little strange. He opened his mouth, then said nothing. Vanna, more straightforward, spoke instead: “Shouldn’t we think a bit about Mr. Tyrian’s mental and physical health?”

“Reading more books is better than watching burlesque shows,” Duncan said with a wave of his hand. “Besides, with me watching over him, nothing would happen… Enough about that.”

He shook his head, then fixed his gaze on Vanna, deciding to test a few things in a roundabout way.

“Vanna, have you ever heard the title or phrase ‘Leviathan Queen’?”

“Leviathan Queen?” Vanna froze, genuine confusion on her face. “Never heard of it… Is that the ruler of some city-state? But I’ve never heard of any city-state with that name.”

Duncan watched Vanna’s expression while also focusing his senses, checking whether any abnormal aura fluctuations or supernatural phenomena appeared around them.

He was very curious whether mentioning the name “Leviathan Queen” in the Mortal Realm would trigger anything.

But after half a minute, nothing happened.

“Alright, forget that for now,” Duncan said, shaking his head. He turned to Morris: “LH-02. Have you ever heard of it?”

“No,” Morris said, puzzled. But seeing the seriousness in Duncan’s expression, he still thought hard before shaking his head. “It sounds like some kind of machine code.”

The reactions of the two Saints did not look fake.

They truly had never heard those two titles.

But that still did not rule out the possibility that the two titles corresponded to the storm Goddess Gamona and Rahm the God of Wisdom.

After all, above the Saints there was still the Pope, and above the great city Cathedrals there were the “pilgrim Cathedral arks” that cruised the Boundless Sea for long periods. The secrets closest to the Gods were all kept in those places far from the mortal world.

“Forget these two names for now,” Duncan said at last, after confirming that nothing had happened in the cabin. He let out a breath and shook his head. “Don’t mention them to anyone. Especially after we leave the Vanished’s range, do not say those words to anyone.”

Chapter 456: The Divinely Blessed (?)

Noticing the serious tone in Duncan’s words, Vanna instinctively started to make all kinds of guesses in her head. But the next second she forced herself to stop, and nodded solemnly together with Morris.

Controlling one’s curiosity was a basic rule for surviving in this world.

After he was sure Morris and Vanna understood how serious this was, Duncan let out a breath. Then he nodded to Alice beside him and said: “Clean up this pile of things on the table. Don’t throw them into the sea, just burn them.”

“Okay!”

Watching Alice quickly clean up the mess on the table, Duncan sat back down in his chair. His mind was still replaying the scenes he had seen in that strange dark space, and he was thinking about the information revealed in that “conversation”.

At the same time, he was also thinking about how to contact that dark space again.

The handwritten copy could not bear the impact of the “truth”… Then where was the original of this “Blasphemous Tome”? If he got the original, could he build a stable link with that strange dark space? Or… were there other supernatural items that could do something similar?

Duncan remembered the time he had been Dreamwalking on the Vanished and then accidentally entered another Vanished in Subspace. Behind the captain's cabin door on that other Vanished was that same strange dark space.

So he boldly guessed that the "dark space" itself was a real "place" inside Subspace, and that connecting to it needed certain media and techniques. The handwritten copy Morris had brought had helped him build that link, but it did not have to be the only usable "medium". If he could find a way to visit that "other Vanished" again, that might also work.

A way… Subspace?

Duncan frowned and quickly pulled his thoughts back from that direction.

He was not sure if that idea was his own, or something Subspace had "released" into him.

But one thing was clear.

He needed more "samples" – whether it was the Suntist's Golden Mask, the copy of the Blasphemous Tome from that Annihilator, or whatever that Ender had in his hands. All of them would help him understand the truth of this world.

Thinking of this, Duncan raised his head at once and looked at Morris and Vanna opposite him: "Do you know where I can get more items like this? I mean things like this 'Blasphemous Tome', the items cultists use for major rituals and preaching."

"You want more?" Morris was shocked. Then he thought it over carefully, and shook his head: "This… will be very hard. The True Gods' Church and the city-states' authority often seize Cult items, but usually, after the necessary identification and research, these things are destroyed, no matter how special or valuable they are as objects."

Duncan raised his eyebrows: “Destroyed directly? No samples kept?”

“No samples, only records,” Vanna answered. In this field, this Inquisitor was clearly more professional than Morris. “Some things are especially dangerous. For those, not even full records are kept. There are only descriptive texts that have been ‘translated’ and ‘safely edited’, and even those must be stored in special archives, or only kept in the memories of certain ‘Keepers of Secrets’.”

She paused, then went on: “Because any Cult item that really has power also has equal danger and corruption. On top of that, they point directly to a Heretic deity, and this danger and corruption grows with time. We often cannot predict how much harm they may cause, so the safest way is to keep no samples. And also…”

“And also, people’s hearts are hard to guess, and even the strongest guardian has moments when their weakness shows,” Morris took over when he saw Vanna hesitate. “Wardens who guard blasphemous items can be tempted. They can slowly change without noticing it. Sometimes they do not even know they have already fallen. In 1666, a Saint of the city-state of Morka talked with a forbidden book under his care in a hallucination. That made the book turn alive, and in the end it caused an accident that killed dozens of people. After that, the city-states stopped keeping samples of seized Heretic items.”

Vanna sighed: “In some sense, Heretic items are even more dangerous than an Anomaly. No matter how high an Anomaly ranks, as long as you master the sealing rules, you can control it and even use it. But with Heretic things… sometimes even they themselves do not know what will come out of there.”

“All right.” Duncan rubbed his forehead. “Looks like we can’t count on getting samples from the city-states… We’ll have to find wild cultists and

take them out on the spot."

Hearing the captain's words, the corner of Vanna's mouth twitched. She hesitated and said: "If… you really are interested, I can try to borrow some records from the Cathedral. The items themselves have all been destroyed, but the safe research documents still exist."

"…If possible, then help me find some records," Duncan said with a nod.

But he felt those materials would not help him much. What he needed was not data. He needed to find a fitting "medium" among those Heretic items.

That Blasphemous Tome just now had already proved one thing. The same supernatural item might appear in a different "form" to him than to an ordinary person. The knowledge that the scholars of the True Gods' Church had written down would most likely be useless to him.

But still, gaining more knowledge about the supernatural field could never hurt.

Right then, a noisy clamor from outside the captain's cabin suddenly cut off Duncan and Vanna's conversation.

It sounded like Shirley and Dog chattering all the way over.

Duncan frowned: "Open the door."

Alice ran over at once and opened the cabin door. She saw Shirley and Dog rushing up to the doorway and said: "Hey, don't make such a racket on the ship…"

"I know, I know, but this is important!" Shirley shouted at the door. Her small body squeezed right past Alice into the room. "Captain, Captain! Dog got possessed! It says it saw something really creepy!"

"Dog… got possessed?" Duncan's face twitched. He looked in confusion at the Abyssal Hound that Shirley was dragging in. "It's a Abyssal demon.

How could it get possessed?”

Morris and Vanna wore the same look that said, “You’re already the weird thing, so what could possibly possess you?” Dog, who had been dragged in, rolled and scrambled up off the floor. It really looked nervous and scared: “Really, I saw that thing twice in a row! It popped up in my head when I was reading, staring right at me on the level of my mind…”

“When you were reading?” Duncan frowned as soon as he heard that. “What’s so shocking about that? It happens on this ship all the time. When Nina rushes her homework, she ‘braises’ several a day…”

“Not my folks from back home!” Dog shook its huge dog head at once, and even sounded a bit anxious. “And not the Shadows of the Spirit Realm or some other malevolent spirit either. It was something I have never seen before. That thing appeared right inside my ‘consciousness’. It was like a bunch of strange lights. There was a big one in the center that gave off red light, and around it was a field of smaller ones. It was just like the ‘Starry Sky’ between the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep, with dots of light circling around the red light source in the middle…”

Dog was only halfway through its rambling when Morris suddenly took two quick steps forward: “What did you say? What did you see?!”

This was the first time Dog had seen the gentle and calm old scholar react like this. It was scared, and shrank its neck by reflex: “Uh… a big red glowing orb, with lots of flickering lights around it…”

Morris listened, dumbfounded. He asked Dog to confirm several details over and over. Only then did he finally raise his head.

The old scholar’s face was full of shock and confusion. It was as if someone had punched a hole in the worldview he had built over half his life. For a long time, he could not say anything.

Vanna had also reacted by now. The muscles on her face twitched twice. She hesitated, then turned to Morris: “That sounds… a bit like…”

“God of Wisdom Rahm’s gaze…” Morris muttered. He lowered his head and looked at Dog again, as if he was looking at a rare antique just dug out of the ground. “You received the God of Wisdom’s gaze?”

The captain’s cabin fell silent at once.

After who knew how long, Dog finally lifted its head in a daze: “…What did you say?”

Duncan ignored Dog’s reaction and frowned at Morris: “Are you sure?”

“Unless Dog is lying, there is no other explanation,” Morris said at once. “What it described is exactly the image that forms in the mind of one who receives divine blessing when the God of Wisdom sends down His gaze. I have seen it too. Every believer who follows Rahm is familiar with it.”

Duncan fell silent.

After a long while, he looked at the confused Abyssal demon lying on the floor.

“What were you doing when you saw that scene?”

“I was doing practice problems,” Dog said honestly. “One time it was geometry, the other time algebra.”

Duncan: “…”

He did not say anything. He just kept quietly looking at Dog. He stared at that ugly, huge… dog head.

Chapter 457: Wisdom’s Favor (?)

The awkward, delicate silence in the captain’s cabin lasted for a long time.

At last, it was Duncan who spoke first and broke the silence. He turned his gaze from Dog and looked seriously at old Mr. Morris beside him: “Logically, do you think this makes sense?”

Morris blinked slowly. His face was twisted with confusion, like someone dragged out of bed at two thirty in the morning to revise a thesis. He felt that the trials he had faced back when he advanced to become a Saint were much easier than this puzzle. After struggling for a long time, he finally squeezed out one line: “In all recorded history… no one has ever heard of such a thing… This is beyond what I know.”

“Of course it is beyond it. Dog might be the only Abyssal demon in history who can read,” Duncan said, rubbing his brow with a complicated expression. “Does your doctrine say anywhere that the God of Wisdom gives divine blessing to Abyssal demons?”

“How could there be such a line?” Morris looked like he had just seen a ghost. “Abyssal demons are enemies of civilized society. Not just the God of Wisdom. None of the other Three Gods would have such a rule in their doctrine…”

As soon as he finished, Vanna, who had been stunned for a while, suddenly remembered something and quietly added: “But the doctrine of the God of Wisdom also says that Rahm watches equally over every living being that has a mind and spirit. He gives them the wisdom to understand the world,

and uses the foolishness of the Veil to shield them from the mad and terrible truth… It does not clearly exclude Abyssal demons from the list of ‘intelligent beings’.”

“What Abyssal demons have a mind and spirit?” Morris blurted out. But in the next second his expression turned strange as he slowly turned his head to look at Dog, who was lying on the floor, behaving itself.

“At Dog’s learning speed, by this time next year we could almost sign it up for the middle school entrance exam,” Duncan said in a dry tone. “Maybe one day it will even sit at the same desk as Nina.”

“…I’m a bit lost. I need to calm down,” Morris finally said, and his body swayed a little. He rubbed his forehead and slowly made his way to a chair. After he sat down, he looked up again. His eyes were complicated as he stared at the dog in the middle of the room. “You… besides those scenes that appeared in your mind, did you feel anything else? Did you hear Him speak to you? Or did you suddenly gain a brand-new understanding of some knowledge?”

“No.” Dog shook its head hard. “I just saw those lights twice in a row, and both times they scared me. Other than that I did not hear or feel anything…”

“So you only saw ‘Him’? You did not receive any revelation?” Morris seemed to have calmed down and started to think seriously. “Then did you feel any increase in your ability to calculate or remember? After gazing at those ‘lights’ for a long time under the gaze, when you returned to the Mortal Realm, did your vision feel different from before?”

Dog kept shaking its head: “No, none of that. And I did not gaze at those ‘lights’ for a long time. I just took one look, then I was pulled back to the Mortal Realm.”

“Just one look? Then you were pulled back to the Mortal Realm?” Morris froze. Clearly this also clashed with what he knew. “That is not right… The God of Wisdom’s gaze comes with a long mental exchange. Even if mortals cannot understand that exchange, the whole process is definitely longer than ‘one look’… How were you pulled back?”

“It felt like Shirley pulled me back,” Dog said after thinking about it. It raised its head and rubbed against Shirley’s arm. “Right when I started to feel like I was going to be ‘taken away’ by those lights, I felt a great force come from the symbiotic pact chain, and then I woke up. But Shirley herself does not seem to remember.”

At once, all the eyes in the room turned to Shirley again.

The girl, now the focus of everyone’s gaze, shrank her neck by instinct. But right after that she showed a proud smile, like a child bragging after doing something impressive.

Only Duncan’s expression grew stranger as it shifted a few times.

Vanna was still puzzled: “I have never heard of a symbiotic pact between Abyssal demons and humans having the power to block a deity’s gaze… Could it be because the symbiotic pact between Shirley and Dog is closer than that of ordinary Annihilators?”

“Ahem, maybe what pulled Dog back was not the power of the symbiotic pact,” Duncan coughed twice. He raised his hand and pointed at Shirley, who was still grinning foolishly. “It might be the power of illiteracy.”

Vanna: “…?”

Shirley: “…?”

Everyone stared, speechless, and Shirley’s expression changed by the second. Morris looked at Duncan in shock. He had always known that the

captain’s way of thinking was broader than most people’s, but he had never guessed it would be broad in this direction.

However, after a short moment of shock, Morris could not help following this line of thought. The more he thought about it… the more it somehow seemed reasonable?

“Maybe at that moment there was a struggle over Dog in the supernatural field. On one side was the God of Wisdom’s gaze, on the other was its illiterate partner. And in the end…” Duncan rubbed his temples and sighed. “The despairing illiterate defeated the deity who wanted to recruit a student.”

“Logically… logically…” Morris opened his mouth and muttered the word several times, then gave up and spread his hands. “Forget it. I do not know how to work out the logic either. If I wrote a paper about this, the scholars of Morka would probably fight to the blood in the city center. Let us just assume things really happened this way.”

A strange and hard-to-hold-in mood filled the captain’s cabin. Shirley stood in the middle of the room and looked like she was about to cry. She looked at Duncan, then at Morris, and finally pointed at Dog with a miserable face: “Then… then did I hold Dog back? It was… it clearly was…”

In that moment, and maybe for the only time in her life, the thought that she should study hard really rose up in Shirley’s mind. But the next second, Duncan’s voice cut off her thought: “Do not rush to conclusions yet. Maybe… this matter is not as simple as we think.”

Shirley dropped her sadness at once: “Huh?”

Duncan did not answer her question right away. Instead, he looked at Dog: “Dog, you just said that while you were gazing at those lights you felt like you were going to be ‘taken away’?”

Dog nodded at once.

Duncan turned to Morris again: “Would someone blessed by the God of Wisdom feel like they were about to be ‘taken away’?”

“No.” Morris now also seemed to sense something. He shook his head, and his tone grew more serious. “A normal divine blessing is a friendly exchange and enlightenment of the mind. The one who receives divine blessing stays clear and joyful. They would never feel any tendency toward a runaway state.”

“If a Abyssal demon really had wisdom ‘poured’ into it by God of Wisdom Rahm, or received some kind of… divine favor, what would happen?” Duncan asked at once.

“I… do not know. This has never happened before. But by logic it could be a very dangerous process.” Morris’s mind worked fast, and he understood what Duncan meant at once. “There is a natural conflict between the four True Gods and the ‘Elder Gods’ that fall into mad runaway states. That conflict is not limited to fights in the literal sense. It is a basic ‘mutual exclusion’ between their creations or retainers. Abyssal demons, as the ‘offspring’ of the Abyssal Lord, naturally have the traits of chaos and corruption. Dog is no exception to this. And for the God of Wisdom…”

Morris paused and looked at Shirley with a grave face: “Even if my Lord has no malice, His radiance would still naturally break Dog’s mind. The result would be…”

Morris did not finish. The others in the room all fell into their own thoughts for a moment. Then the AI, which had been resting with eyes closed on the enchanted sea chart table, suddenly jumped up. As if it had gone crazy, it flapped its wings hard and let out a sharp, bizarre cry: “KZZZRT TATATATATATA!”

After that one loud shout, it shot up into the air, then dropped back onto the table with a thump like a rock. It flapped and stood up again, then casually strolled a few steps as if nothing had happened. It came to Goathead's side, tilted its head, and said: "Wanna top up Q-coins?"

Everyone was startled by the pigeon spirit's strange and glitchy behavior, and no one understood what it was yelling about. Duncan's expression, however, changed slightly.

The next second, a sentence suddenly floated up in his mind: [Two incompatible operating systems sharing data would cause a fatal error.]

Along with a brief moment of sudden clarity and a head full of wild ideas, he slowly turned his head and looked at Dog.

"Could there be a data conflict between the Abyssal Lord and LH-02…" he muttered.

"Huh?" Dog did not react at first. "Captain, what did you say?"

"No, nothing." Duncan knew it would be hard to explain how much he had just connected in that instant. He only waved his hand, then looked at Shirley, who was still staring at him in confusion. In his mind, he tore apart and rebuilt his vocabulary several times before finally finding something to say: "Shirley, pulling Dog back might have been good for it. I mean, only 'might'. It may have kept Dog from being corrupted or swallowed by the will of God of Wisdom Rahm."

Shirley's mind turned quickly for a moment, and she seemed to finally understand what Duncan meant. The light returned to her eyes at once: "Ah, so… keeping my distance from that God of Wisdom is actually a good thing?"

What else could Duncan say? He could only nod.

The moment he nodded, Shirley's face lit up with joy: "Then from now on I have a reason not to do homework, right?! I have to pull Dog back!"

Duncan: "…?!"

He had never thought that this would be the first thing this young lady would think of.

But before he could say anything this time, Morris reacted first: "It is not that simple."

Shirley froze: "Huh?"

The old mister looked very serious: "My Lord does not grant divine blessing based only on knowledge level, and the other way around is also true. And from what I have seen these days, even if you did homework every day, it would not change how the God of Wisdom keeps you outside His door."

Shirley: "??"

Chapter 458: The Risk of gaze

According to Morris, the God of Wisdom's standards for granting a divine blessing seemed to be a very subtle thing.

"In most people's minds, a believer of the God of Wisdom has to be a well-learned grand scholar, or some eccentric genius with shocking talent in a certain field. That view is not exactly wrong. After all, most believers of the God of Wisdom do meet the two conditions of being 'learned' and 'brilliant'. But nothing is absolute."

Morris sat on a chair near the captain's cabin door. He ignored the subtle look on Shirley's face beside him as he explained seriously.

"First of all, being favored by the God of Wisdom does not always require a very high level of knowledge. Take Dog right now. Dog learns very fast, but compared to the properly trained believers who passed all three rounds of the Church exams, Dog's academic level is clearly not enough. Yet Dog still received Rahm's gaze. In other city-states, there were also many believers, and even Saints who later became famous, who received revelation long before they mastered any deep knowledge.

"The most notable example was Saint Coleford, a professor more than two hundred years ago. This grand scholar received revelation at the age of sixteen, when he was still a dock laborer who could not even read. Only after that revelation did he get the chance to touch the knowledge in books.

"There was also a case that was the complete opposite. In the city-state of Morka, there was a well-known scholar who spent his whole life trying to

gain the favor of the God of Wisdom. He almost passed every exam at the Truth Academy, yet he never saw Rahm's radiance before he died. Later, the Truth Academy posthumously granted this scholar the honorary title of Saint. And cases like this are not unique."

Duncan rubbed his chin thoughtfully: "So it sounds like the God of Wisdom's 'admission standards' are a bit arbitrary?"

"I wouldn't say arbitrary. What I just mentioned counts as 'exceptions'. Otherwise, the Truth Academy would not use the unified exams as an effective first filter for believers," Morris said with a shake of his head. "We can only say that gods are simply impossible to fathom. Even the four True Gods are the same. They have their own standards for measuring the world, and mortals over tens of thousands of years have only managed to summarize a few of those rules by chance."

Duncan listened to Morris's serious explanation but did not speak. He sat there with a thoughtful look, holding his own opinion in his heart.

The old mister's earlier explanations and examples might have been fine, but his final "conclusion" still had room for debate.

Were the Gods' patterns of behavior really impossible to guess? During Rahm's gaze, were all those "exceptions" and even "absurd" cases truly random, or was there some other reason behind them?

Without noticing, that strange dark space surfaced again in his mind, along with the exchanges he had seen in the darkness.

That individual labeled "LH-02", who most likely was Rahm, the God of Wisdom, had said a few words at the end of that exchange that bothered him deeply.

If that information had really happened in real time, if LH-02 really was Rahm, and if everything was as Duncan suspected, then the so-called

“Gods” in the mouths of mortal beings truly deserved deep thought.

Lost in thought, he lifted his eyelids without meaning to and looked at Dog.

Just as Morris had said, Dog had shown an amazing gift for learning, but Dog’s current “academic level” was still far from those grand scholars who were long famous in the Truth Academy. Yet this same Dog, who had only shaken off illiteracy not long ago, had received a direct gaze from Rahm, the God of Wisdom. It was an honor that tens of thousands of scholars in the Truth Academy would not even dare to dream of for their entire lives, though for Dog it did not seem to be a good thing.

So what exactly had attracted Rahm? Dog’s “talent”? Dog’s drive to learn? Or…

Was it because Dog was a mutated individual that belonged to a Abyssal Deep “cluster”? Because this Abyssal Hound had gained a “heart” and happened to match LH-02’s identification criteria?

Dog shrank back without meaning to. Duncan’s silent gaze made Dog’s whole body prickle. After holding back for a long time, Dog finally could not help speaking: “Captain, you…”

Duncan did not answer Dog. Instead, he turned and looked at Morris: “In your judgment, is it possible that one day Shirley might suddenly meet the God of Wisdom’s standards and be accepted by Rahm?”

Morris froze for a moment, then immediately shook his head. “That is absolutely impossible!”

“So sure?” Duncan asked with a very serious tone. “You just said Rahm’s standards are not that absolute. Sometimes even someone who cannot read can suddenly be chosen.”

“There are exceptions to the God of Wisdom’s standards, but at least there is one thing that has never gone wrong. Anyone who has been rejected once

will not get a second chance. There are very few clear cases of being rejected by the God of Wisdom in history, but at least…"

Morris paused there and glanced at Shirley.

"At least when Dog was about to be 'taken away', Shirley was able to pull Dog back into the Mortal Realm by her own strength. That is already the clearest 'rejection' of a mortal by the God of Wisdom that I can imagine."

Duncan gave Shirley a complicated look. Shirley still seemed a bit confused. The young lady looked left and right, and only after a long pause did she finally ask: "So?"

"So you still have to do your homework," Duncan said without hesitation. "Don't even think about using 'shielding Dog from divine revelation' as an excuse to refuse to study."

"Ah…" Shirley's face fell at once. Her mind worked faster than usual this time. "You just said I am not cut out for studying. Even the God of Wisdom has clearly said he doesn't want this brain of mine…"

"More than ninety percent of the people in this world never even get the chance to enter the Truth Academy. Sixty percent only take the exams to get a diploma. And almost one hundred percent will never become Rahm's Saints or receive his gaze," Duncan said, gazing quietly into Shirley's eyes. His expression and tone were both serious. "Do you think I decided to teach you to read and write just so you could become a grand scholar like Morris?"

Shirley was startled by how serious Duncan looked. She opened her mouth a few times but did not manage to say anything. After a moment, she slowly lowered her eyes: "I…I know… I'm sorry, I was being stubborn…"

"It's fine. You are still a child in my eyes. Children are allowed to be stubborn," Duncan said with a gentle shake of his head. "Relax. I'm not

scolding you. I was just thinking… what will happen to Dog in the future."

"Me?" Dog, who had been lying obediently to the side, lifted its head in confusion, as if it had not followed Duncan's train of thought. "What will happen to me in the future?"

Duncan looked into Dog's eyes: "Have you ever thought that you might receive Rahm's gaze a third time, or even a fourth?"

Dog froze, then finally reacted. Its "eyes" – Dog technically had no eyes – but its whole body clearly trembled.

"Th-then I can't read books anymore?" Its voice was tight with nerves.

"The God of Wisdom is not some 'shadow' that gets drawn over by books. As a deity, he has already noticed you," Morris answered from the side. The old scholar shook his head, his eyes heavy. "I cannot guess his will. But since he has taken an interest in you once, there is no guarantee he will not come looking for you again. That will be true even if you stop reading in the future. It might even…"

The old scholar stopped for a moment. His expression turned a bit strange, as if he was not sure whether he should describe his own deity this way. In the end, he still shook his head and went on: "You could even say that as long as you keep 'thinking', your mind will always remain within the God of Wisdom's sight. When he looks your way again depends only on his mood."

The red glow in Dog's eye sockets visibly quivered.

When Duncan heard Morris's words, some strange feelings rose in his heart. From this description, Rahm's "divine blessing" sounded almost like an eldritch god's curse.

But then he thought it over. From the point of view of a Abyssal demon, any divine blessing from a True God probably was not much different from an

eldritch god’s curse.

This time, even Alice, who had been silent at the side, reacted. She suddenly spoke up: “Then won’t Dog be living in danger every single day from now on?”

“There is danger, yes. But as long as the link between Dog and Shirley stays, that danger might not be fatal,” Duncan said with a shake of his head. “From Dog’s description and my own… well, my own guesses, Rahm does not seem hostile. He may not even have realized that the ‘mind’ that just appeared in his sight belongs to a Abyssal demon. On that basis, he likely will not use a more ‘violent’ way to ‘take’ Dog.”

Hearing Duncan’s judgment, Dog could only lower its head. There was a hint of sorrow in its tone: “Sigh… I guess that’s the only way to think about it.”

“Take it easy. You and Shirley still carry my mark. Even if the worst happens and Shirley can’t hold on to you, I should still sense something,” Duncan said, comforting the anxious hound. “I have never tried it, but I don’t mind testing what it’s like to snatch a person… or a dog… out of a True God’s hands.”

“And I will definitely hold on to you!” Shirley added at once. She patted her chest and shook the symbiotic pact chain in her hand. “Dog, don’t worry. This brain of mine has been clearly rejected by the God of Wisdom! It will definitely work as your safety anchor!”

Dog had been about to be moved by Duncan’s words, but Shirley’s proud and confident tone caught it off guard. Dog could only raise its head and stare blankly at her: “That… that’s not really something to be proud of, is it?”

Shirley did not answer. She just kept grinning foolishly.

But her fingers gripping the chain clenched tighter and tighter.

Chapter 459: The Person in the Mirror

Shirley left with Dog, who was still a little uneasy. Vanna and Morris left as well. The captain's cabin grew quiet, leaving only Duncan, Alice, and the dozing pigeon.

Alice was wiping the furnishings and windows in the room. Duncan sat behind the desk, lost in long thought.

A creaking sound came from the desk. Goathead's skull slowly turned toward Duncan: "Are you still thinking about Rahm, the God of Wisdom?"

"Not the God of Wisdom – Gods," Duncan said. He leaned back in his chair, a thoughtful look on his face. "The Gods… what kind of connection do they really have with this world?"

"Who knows?" Goathead muttered. "The scriptures of each church paint them as the makers and protectors of mortal order. Many cultists believe the opposite. They say the Gods twisted the world and even stole the credit for the Genesis Protocol. The things Morris saw in that book, The Blasphemous Tome, offered another fresh explanation. The 'lost Elder Kings' it spoke of seem to be the deities we have now. Maybe all these views are wrong, or maybe each of them holds a part of the truth…"

Goathead rambled on, then shook his head again.

"But if you want my opinion, my view is… they don't seem very useful. They don't really make the world any better, and they haven't made it much

worse either.”

“But for most ordinary people in this world, the protection of the Gods is real,” Duncan said casually. “That shelter let most mortals survive.”

“Yes. Survive. A way of preserving the status quo,” Goathead said slowly. “It was like Frostholm’s state over the past fifty years. Before the balance broke, no one knew how many shadows of disaster had piled up beneath it. But at least everyone was still alive.”

Duncan neither agreed nor disagreed with Goathead’s judgment. He only thought for a while before speaking again: “When Dog thinks, Dog enters Rahm’s sight. There are also many famous examples in history of people ‘blessed by the gods’. They all suddenly received a gaze in the middle of their daily lives and formed a link with the Four Gods. So can we see it this way? The Four Gods set up a kind of ‘monitoring’ or ‘scanning’ system over the beings in the mortal world. They sense certain special nodes to check the state of the Mortal Realm. Does that actually mean their interference with and sense of the present world are indirect and limited?”

“…Those True God churches won’t like the way you put that. It sounds like you are studying some kind of machine, with no reverence at all for the deities.”

“Reverence is the farthest thing from understanding. I don’t want to revere them. I just want to understand them,” Duncan said calmly. “After all, we have already helped them clean up two messes.”

…

Footsteps sounded in the long corridor of the great cathedral. Their steady echoes seemed to knock on the time piled up inside this ancient building.

Agatha, in a black dress, walked toward the depths of the sanctuary. She brought no attendants with her. Only her own shadow kept company with

this body that had lost its life yet still moved. On both sides of the corridor, the light of gas lamps and candles crossed and mingled in the wall niches, making the shadow cast on the ground dim and unsteady.

Only after she returned to her own room and closed the door did this archbishop and gatekeeper, who had seemed calm and steady all the way, finally relax. She leaned back against the door and let out a long sigh.

She no longer needed to breathe, but a “sigh” was a sign of being human. She still used it as a symbol to help herself relax.

After all, she did not want to seem… too much like a corpse.

Order in the great cathedral had been restored. The smaller cathedrals across the city-state were also slowly getting back on track. The whole city was still tense, but after the Sea Mist Fleet stepped in, the chaos in each district, especially criminal cases, had been quickly contained.

On the other hand, the distribution of supplies and the work of handling the dead and survivors were still a tangled mess. Severe staff shortages still troubled every department. But after the Sea Mist Fleet entered the city, they had “miraculously” found a large group of professionals from every corner of the city-state. These people either had administrative skills or knew the city’s grassroots operations well, and they were placed into City Hall.

According to City Hall, the people “recommended” by the Sea Mist Fleet were learning and taking over each department’s work at an astonishing speed. In just a few more days, the problem of staff shortages everywhere would be greatly eased.

At the same time, the public opinion work needed for the fleet’s entry into the city, and the propaganda focused on General Tyrian Abnomar himself,

were steadily moving forward. The reorganization and merging of the city-state's remaining navy with the Sea Mist Fleet had also begun.

The new governor had not yet held an official inauguration ritual, but the city had already fallen under his control at an amazing speed.

This was the kind of development the officials of Frostholm's authority had once only imagined in nightmares. But for the Frostholm of today, it was all a good thing.

Agatha could finally relax a little.

A corpse did not get tired, but her mind still needed a break.

After leaning against the door for a few minutes, Agatha shook her head, then slowly walked to her dressing table and sat down to rest.

Her figure appeared in the mirror above the dressing table.

The feeling of being watched made Agatha jerk her head up.

There was no one else in the room, and she did not sense any unfamiliar presence.

Yet the sense of being watched was definitely not an illusion.

The blind priest with her eyes covered lifted her head and carefully felt for any tiny movement around her, sensing the flow of every breath of air. Her "gaze" slowly swept over the room and then over the mirror on the dressing table.

In her sight, the lifeless furnishings in the room showed up as vague, dim outlines, giving off a chill like that of a grave.

But in the next second, the feeling of being watched vanished.

The figure in the mirror shifted its gaze.

Agatha in front of the dressing table suddenly froze. It was as if she had sensed something instead. After a brief hesitation, she slowly raised her arm and reached toward the mirror.

A cold, hard feeling met her fingers. It was a lifeless sheet of glass.

The figure in the mirror hesitated. After hesitating for who knew how long, she also raised her arm and slowly brought her fingers forward.

The feeling of fingertip touching fingertip came all at once, with a faint warmth between them.

In the next instant, new light and shadow appeared in Agatha's murky darkness of sight. In that lifeless mirror surface, a hazy outline that gave off a faint glow suddenly appeared.

The two of them faced each other quietly across the mirror. The room fell into a brief silence.

After a long time, the Agatha in front of the mirror finally broke the silence: "You're there?"

There was a trace of hesitation in her voice.

"Mm," a voice answered, as if it had slipped straight into her mind. "I'm here."

"When… did you appear?"

"The key," the voice in Agatha's mind said calmly. "I have been here since the moment you took that key."

Agatha did not speak for a while.

The feeling was… strange. She could clearly tell that the voice in her mind was her own voice. She could even feel the faint emotions that came with it when it spoke. Yet she also clearly knew that the one talking to her was

another being. It was not a hallucination in her own mind, not a personality split off by madness, not some kind of “attachment” of herself.

Unbelievable.

“Unbelievable,” the her in the mirror said. “If I had to compare it to something, it feels a bit like a split personality. But it clearly isn’t…”

“Even the best psychiatrist probably couldn’t solve this one.”

“Let’s not give the psychiatrists in the city-state more trouble. They already have nothing but trouble these days.”

Agatha suddenly raised her hand and rubbed her brow.

Talking with “another self” like this was a feeling she had never had before. While they spoke, she kept having the illusion that she could no longer tell which one was the “real” her. There was no actual confusion in her mind yet, but she still could not help stopping to sort out her thoughts.

After a moment, she lifted her head again and “looked” at herself in the mirror.

“So that key… kept your soul? And then used it as a medium to send you into my…”

She trailed off there. She did not seem to know how to describe her current state.

The shadow in front of her… was it in her mind, in her senses, or… just a projection on some psychological level?

“I don’t know either,” the voice in her head answered. “I don’t know if I even have a soul. I don’t know the details of the process, and I don’t know how that key did all this. My consciousness was in a chaotic state for a long time, and I’ve only been awake for the past two days.”

Then the voice hesitated for a moment. A few seconds later, it went on: “From the looks of it now, that key should be able to store and move memories. But probably only the Queen of Frostholm knows all of its secrets.”

“The Queen of Frostholm…” Agatha muttered, almost to herself. “It seems we should tell the Captain about this…”

“…But in theory, we should first report to the Death Sanctuary headquarters,” the Agatha in the mirror reminded her.

The Agatha in front of the mirror paused at that. Her expression shifted a little before she spoke again, hesitating: “That… does sound right. But the Death Sanctuary is now cruising at the far edge of the civilized world. They may not have time to care about this kind of ‘personal matter’.”

She stopped there and lifted her head to look at the mirror.

“What do you think?”

The Agatha in the mirror thought for a moment.

Thoughts and memories flowed slowly between them. Understanding and emotion echoed on both sides of the mirror.

A faint green flame appeared in the eyes of the Agatha in the mirror.

“I also think we should tell the Captain. He is clearly very experienced when it comes to mirrors.”

Chapter 460: Secret Construction

A presence that was drawing closer suddenly cut off their current conversation.

Agatha pulled back the fingers that were touching the mirror at once: “Someone is coming. It is an Attendant.”

“I understand. I will not scare him,” the voice in the mirror spoke directly in her mind. “I am right beside you. When you look carefully, you will find me.”

Agatha nodded, but just before the “her” in the mirror left, she suddenly thought of something and spoke without thinking: “Are you… cold over there?”

“…Not anymore.”

The voice faded from her mind, and the feeling of being under a gaze also slowly vanished. The other Agatha reflected in the mirror returned to a normal mirror world – her eyes were covered with black cloth, she wore a priestess’s robe, and she stood quietly in front of the mirror.

Agatha hesitated for a moment. She reached toward the mirror again and touched only cold glass. It almost made her wonder if everything that had just happened was only an illusion.

Almost at the same time, she heard footsteps reach the door, followed by a soft knocking sound: “Archbishop, are you inside?”

The old subordinates in the Guardians still habitually called her “Gatekeeper”, while the clerical priests in the Cathedral had already started to address her as “Archbishop”.

Agatha smoothed her expression and turned around calmly: “I am here. Come in.”

The door opened. A high-ranking Attendant of the Cathedral in a gray short robe appeared in the doorway and bowed to Agatha: “Archbishop, an urgent message has come from City Hall. Please go to South Harbor at once – General Tyrian is already waiting for you there.”

“City Hall? Asking me to go to South Harbor?” Agatha frowned without thinking. The news felt unusual. “Did they say what it is about?”

“No. They only said it is an emergency and not fit to spread,” the high-ranking Attendant answered, sounding a little hesitant. “But… General Tyrian sent a word. He said, ‘The Master of Fire might be interested.’”

Agatha’s expression changed slightly at once.

“I understand. Prepare a car. I will leave immediately.”

Before long, Agatha was sitting in a steam car heading for South Harbor. In light of the message Tyrian had sent, she did not bring any attendants. She went alone.

On the way to the Harbor district, her mind was full of one guess after another.

What had happened that could make that “General Tyrian” react like this? In the last great battle, South Harbor had been occupied for a time by replica monsters. The cleanup was still going on even now… Had they found something in all that rubble? Was it a blasphemous sacred relic left behind by the Annihilators, or some suspicious “sample” that remained after the replica monsters faded away?

Either way, it still should not have made General Tyrian react like this.

With these messy thoughts that almost made her irritable, Agatha quickly passed through the streets that now looked empty and cold under martial law. She crossed checkpoint after checkpoint and finally reached the southern Harbor district, which was still under full lockdown.

soldiers of the city-state Guard Corps were holding every intersection. Heavily armed Church Guardians patrolled among the badly damaged buildings, inspecting them and marking areas of corruption that still needed to be dealt with. priests were collecting samples in those corrupted zones. Now and then she even saw Academy students in heavy protective gear moving between the ruins under the lead of their mentors – they were civil engineering students, here today to check the condition of key Harbor facilities and prepare for later repairs.

The car stopped in an open space at the edge of the cordoned-off area. Two soldiers led Agatha on foot through one busy “work site” after another, heading toward a rather remote direction inside the Harbor district.

In the end, they stopped in front of a large building that looked from the outside like a warehouse.

“We can only bring you this far,” one of the soldiers who had led the way turned back and said to Agatha with a hint of apology. “We do not know the details of what is going on below – the General will explain it to you.”

Below?

Agatha sharply caught that choice of word, but she did not ask anything. She only nodded lightly to the two soldiers in thanks and then walked toward the warehouse, which looked as if it had been sealed for a long time and still carried traces of war on its walls.

Guarding the warehouse door was not the city-state Guard Corps, but a squad of Undying sailors.

In Agatha's eyes, living people were warm, clear figures that gave off a faint glow. The Undying were hollow, pale bodies. A smoke that made one think of ashes rose within their blurred outlines. After she realized that this whole warehouse was guarded only by Undying, Agatha became even more certain that something very unusual was going on here.

Compared with the city-state Guard Corps, General Tyrian clearly trusted his Undying legion more.

"Lady," one of the Undying guarding the door came over. His upper body and lower body were already separated. Nearly a quarter of his torso was missing, and only a few ragged strips of cloth drifted between the two halves to hold them together. Over his upper body he wore a new coat that showed he was a Frostholm soldier, and on the sleeve of the coat he had an armband of the Queen's Guard Corps. This Undying sailor stood in front of Agatha and, despite his terrible appearance, gave a perfectly standard military salute: "Once you go in, someone will take you to the shaft lift. The General is already waiting for you in the underground facility."

Agatha nodded. By now she was certain that unless she reached the place herself, no one along the way would tell her what lay underground.

Inside the warehouse, she saw another squad of Undying sailors who had come to meet her. Under their guidance, she found a shaft lift hidden in a corner of the warehouse, as if it had been "dug out" from behind a pile of fake wall panels.

She stepped into the shaft lift, and the iron cage began to descend. It went down for several minutes before finally reaching an underground facility buried deep in the earth, a place that had never appeared in any official record.

She stepped out of the cage. In the dim, hazy sight of her special senses, she “saw” a wide hall. Patches of thick sludge left behind after the replica incursion faded still lay all around. Undying sailors were cleaning those things away, and a tall figure was standing at the far end of the hall, guarding a large door.

It was General Tyrian, the new governor of the city-state of Frostholm.

Agatha walked toward that figure.

“Oh, Lady Agatha, you are finally here,” Tyrian greeted her first. “I thought you would come the way the rumors say, riding a gust of wind straight from the upper central district…”

“I am used to traveling with the Ashen Wind, but I am not going to run here across half the city,” Agatha said casually. Then she raised her head and turned her sight toward the large door behind Tyrian. “What is going on here? Why is there such a facility under South Harbor?”

“You are surprised. Everyone is surprised,” Tyrian said, shaking his head. “This facility does not exist in any official record. If we had not been clearing the ruins here, we would never have found it. Guess what we discovered in this hidden large facility?”

“Do not keep me in suspense, General,” Agatha sighed. At the place where her eyes lay beneath the black cloth, a wisp of ghostly green flame flashed. “There are no outsiders here.”

Tyrian smiled, then his face turned serious at last. He stepped slightly to the side: “See for yourself. It is just behind this door.”

Agatha turned her “gaze” on the door.

She could still make out traces of blood on it, as well as bullet holes and dents left by fighting. Clearly, during the defense of Frostholm, there had also been a battle deep inside this unknown facility.

Now, both the intruders and the guardians had vanished from this battlefield.

She reached out, pressed her hand to the door, and pushed. The locking mechanism had already been broken. The heavy alloy doors slid open with a loud creaking sound. A larger space lit by gas lamps and electric lights appeared in Agatha's senses.

The salty, fishy smell of sea water rushed into her nose.

She stood at the entrance of the hall, staring in shock at the thing in her sight – a huge machine shaped like an oval egg, fixed between sturdy beams overhead.

Below the slanted side of the machine, at the end of a long chute, lay the source of the sea smell. It was clearly a waterway that led straight to the open ocean.

She stood there for a long time in astonished silence before finally breaking it: "This is…"

"It is a Deep Dive device, Lady," Tyrian let out a long breath. His tone carried a strange mix of emotions. "It was built from the blueprint of the last generation of Deep Dive devices and uses a lot of newer technology. It is much more advanced than the one we used back in the day."

Her thoughts were confirmed. Agatha could not help but draw in a breath. Then she suddenly turned her head: "Who built this?"

"Maybe Governor Winston, or maybe you also have to add several former governors," Tyrian said slowly. "We have found no detailed construction and approval records, so we cannot be sure who gave the first order to build it. From the few documents we did find, this facility was still running in secret at least up until two months ago."

Chapter 461: Convergence

Deep underground behind layer after layer of seals, a hidden facility that led straight to the sea, a vast project no one knew about, secrets buried under piles of truth and lies – half a century of concealment, hopes and dreams from the past, and fears and taboos that had stretched until today.

All of it now came together in front of Agatha, cast in cold metal and hanging in silence among beams that crossed like a skeleton, like frozen years that had somehow started to move again.

A Submersible, secretly built by the city-state's authority.

Agatha stood quietly before the huge, silent machine. Through the thick black cloth over her eyes, she used her gaze on this mass of steel. A silent pressure seemed to skip at the edge of her senses. After a long time, she finally spoke in a hoarse voice and broke the silence: "How did you find it?"

"There was a lot of luck involved," Tyrian said. "I believe that even among Governor Winston's trusted aides, only a handful knew about this. Most of them likely died in the final defense. But after I took over the work at City Hall, I noticed some… abnormal movements of money and personnel, and they all pointed toward a 'closed research project' here in the Harbor."

As he spoke, he turned his head and looked at the giant mass hanging between the steel beams.

"What came after is not very special. Since South Harbor had fallen completely, we decided to search the place from top to bottom," he went on.

“We found a suspicious warehouse, a suspicious shaft, a suspicious underground facility, and a suspicious Submersible.”

Tyrian sounded relaxed, almost light, as he told the story. Even as only a listener, Agatha could not help but admire the skill of this “Steel Vice Admiral”. He had taken over Frostholm and gotten a full picture of everything here so quickly. It was nothing like what a man who had stayed away from the city-state for half a century should be able to do.

A facility this secret could not be found by following a few random clues.

It was as if he had never left Frostholm at all.

“Can this machine still be used?” After a short silence, Agatha could not hold back the question.

“It needs to be checked,” Tyrian said with a shake of his head. “This Submersible was built from the blueprints the Queen of Frostholm left, but it also uses many modern and even current technologies. And there are lots of surface systems in this facility that support the Submersible – air pumps, steel cables, communication devices. We have to figure out their condition and how they work.

“The bad news is that the people who knew these technical details are probably all gone. They died in the defense of Frostholm. When we discovered this underground facility, it was locked from the inside. It seems the people down here were trying to lock those monsters in the quarantine chambers, but sadly… they had no idea how large that disaster really was.”

Tyrian shook his head lightly as he spoke.

“But there is also good news,” he raised his hand and pointed around. “The Submersible is intact. Everything in this hall is intact.”

Agatha did not answer. She only raised her head in silence and turned back toward the way she had come.

The heavy, slightly warped door stood there in her hazy sight. Blood on its surface faintly formed the shape of a handprint. The life in that blood had long since faded, but the outline still gave off a weak glow in her sight.

Tyrian's voice came from beside her, pulling her thoughts back: "Next, I will try to find people who knew about this secret project. Maybe not all the technical staff were inside this facility at the time. If we really cannot find a single surviving technician, then we can only let some old hands in the Sea Mist Fleet try their luck."

Agatha frowned in confusion: "Sea Mist Fleet?"

A faint smile appeared on Tyrian's face: "The ones who took part in the Abyssal Trench Project back then. They will be very surprised when they see this Submersible."

Agatha fell silent again.

Countless feelings rose and fell in her heart. She did not know whether she should sigh over history circling back, or be glad that somehow, everything seemed to be returning to where it should be.

Tyrian also became quiet. The Steel Vice Admiral slowly put away his smile, and his gaze, now solemn, swept slowly across the hall. At last, his eyes rested on the door that led back toward the shaft lift.

He nodded lightly, as if paying respect to these unknown acts of folly and bravery.

…

The sea breeze was gentle, and the white waves rolled.

The roaring power from the steam core pushed the ship forward. The cold wind from the sea drove the clutter from his mind. Lawrence stood on the

high foredeck of the White Oak, wearing the captain's coat he had used for many years, staring out at the sea ahead.

But the old captain's heart was nothing like as calm as he appeared.

A gentle female voice came from the pocket mirror hanging on his chest: "Getting nervous?"

"This nervous feeling has not faded since we left Frostholm," Lawrence clicked his tongue. "After all, we are going to meet that ship on purpose. For a hundred years, captains on the Boundless Sea have only tried their best to run away from that ship, and here we are, sailing toward it on purpose. If the folks at the Explorers' Association heard about this, they would definitely think I have gone mad."

"There are not many captains on the Boundless Sea who are not mad. And you are about to become the brightest legend among these mad captains," Martha said with a laugh in her voice. "Isn't that a little motivating?"

Lawrence sighed: "You are saying that to a man about to be led to the gallows. You tell him that his noose is the best-looking rope in the world – you might even tie it in a bow for him. Do you think that would be comforting?"

Martha in the mirror opened her mouth, about to answer, when a hoarse, noisy voice suddenly came from the mast nearby: "Of course it would! As long as the noose works, you can tie me into a bow if you like!"

The corner of Lawrence's mouth twitched. He turned his head toward the sound.

At the top of the prow, a noose hung from the tall mast. Anomaly 077 had put its own neck through that noose and now dangled there, swinging back and forth with the motion of the ship. It looked eerie and wrong.

“Are you still not coming down?” Lawrence snapped, looking up at the mummified corpse hanging on the mast. “You have been hanging there all day.”

“What if it suddenly starts working? I think I already felt a little sleepy just now,” the mummified corpse shouted, still hanging from the rope. “Let me hang there a bit longer – you already agreed I could choose where I sleep.”

“…I did agree that you could choose where to rest as long as you did not disturb others. But at the time, you did not say you would hang yourself from the mast,” Lawrence glared. “You should give it up. Your sealing method has clearly failed. Going with me to report to the Vanished is your only choice.”

The corpse hanging from the mast let out an exaggerated wail, but Lawrence had no mood to bother with it anymore. He lowered his head again and spoke to the pocket mirror at his chest: “Do you think it will go smoothly?”

“Why are you asking me?”

“Your instincts are always sharp. Back in the day, you were the one who chose the date of every departure.”

“…You even remember that…” Martha’s voice held a sigh, then she gave a small laugh. “Stop worrying so much. You have already accepted your new identity as a member of the Vanished Fleet, haven’t you? And this is not your first time meeting that ship.”

“That is true, but I am still nervous,” Lawrence sighed and straightened his collar without thinking. “Besides, my last meeting with that ship is not worth remembering at all. That scene would be a nightmare for any captain.”

“Look at it this way: at least this time the Vanished will not sail straight toward you and ram you aga—”

A harsh creaking sound suddenly broke in, making Lawrence’s teeth hurt.

In the next second, Lawrence saw layers of ghostly green flame appear out of thin air around the White Oak. At the same time came the deafening roar of the engines and a violent lurch as the helm suddenly turned.

In the blink of an eye, the once calm sea changed completely. On the blue surface, countless terrifying black shadows rose up like strands of hair. The sunlight in the sky dimmed and turned unreal. Thick clouds and mist fell from above like a collapsing curtain, and the whole sea was stained black by those “hair-like” corruptions.

The mummified corpse hanging from the mast almost started screaming at once.

In the corpse’s shrill screams and the sailors’ shouts, Lawrence realized that the White Oak had been dragged into the Spirit Realm by some powerful force. With a heart-shaking roar and a sudden rise of waves ahead, a towering ship burning with fierce flames burst out of the dense fog!

The Vanished had appeared.

Like a burning cliff, it came crashing down toward them, filling the sky.

Anomaly 077’s screams almost shook the whole sea: “It’s going to hit us, it’s going to hit us! Damn it, it really is going to hit us again! I’m done! I want to go home! Let me down! I want to go home! Aaaah—”

Then, right in the middle of the corpse’s shrill cry and the sailors’ panic, the bow of the Vanished suddenly stopped.

It stopped less than half a meter from the starboard bow of the White Oak, in a way that made no sense at all.

Lawrence stood there at the prow, stunned. After a long moment, his eyes finally moved. He slowly tilted his head back and looked up at the ghost ship towering above him in the blazing flames.

The nightmare scene in his memory overlapped with reality in the Mortal Realm. He had once again come to this position and once again saw this doomsday view.

The Vanished had come.

A tall figure appeared in his sight. Duncan Abnomar, the eternal Master of the Vanished, stood high at the ship’s rail, looking down at them.

This was the second time Lawrence had faced this legendary being.

Then he heard Duncan speak. The deep voice rolled like solemn thunder across the sea:

“Lawrence, what in the world is all that racket on your ship?”

Chapter 462: The First Step to a Good Relationship

A spinning gate of blazing fire suddenly expanded over the deck. Then the Master of the Vanisheds Fleet stepped out from the gate.

He was tall and imposing, wrapped in spirit flame, his eyes blazing. His very existence seemed like fear given form upon the Boundless Sea. Wherever his gaze fell, it felt as if all the fires in the mortal world were stirred.

Behind that tall figure came another person: a graceful woman in a dark purple dress, with silver hair down to her waist and a beautiful face, though her skin looked a little pale. She followed closely behind Captain Duncan, her bearing mysterious and elegant, like an attendant.

Lawrence felt his heart pound and his nerves stretch to the limit. He saw Duncan walk toward him, and with every step the captain took, the stubborn spirit form flames on Lawrence's own body burned a little brighter. Only when Duncan finally stopped on the deck did Lawrence come back to himself and lower his head: "Captain."

"Your ship is nice." Duncan said it offhandedly, then looked up and swept his gaze over the exploration ship he had once met only briefly, and whose fate had been tangled with his ever since. At the same time, a faint sense of novelty rose in his heart. Strictly speaking, this was the first time his true body had ever left the Vanished and boarded another ship.

Before stepping onto the White Oak, he had worried that leaving the Vanished might trigger some unforeseeable change. After all, walking through the city-states in an avatar form and letting his true body leave the ship were two very different things. But now it seemed that, at least while he moved within the Vanisheds Fleet, the Vanished did not have any trouble because of his absence.

Lawrence felt a strange mix of emotions. He could not tell whether Captain Duncan's words counted as praise or not. He could only keep his head down in embarrassment: "Uh, as long as you like it…"

"Don't be so nervous. This isn't our first meeting," Duncan said with a smile. Lawrence's reaction was exactly what he expected. He had seen it many times. "Relax. Pretend you're just meeting an ordinary senior from the Explorer Association."

As he spoke, his gaze moved over Lawrence's uniform. At the man's collar he saw the badge of the Explorer Association.

Duncan nodded slightly and added: "Many years ago, I was an Explorer too. Sadly, my badge was lost in Subspace."

Lawrence froze for a moment and then lifted his head, a little hesitant. His taut nerves eased a bit, and his sluggish thoughts finally started working again. He suddenly realized that this terrifying "Subspace Shadow" was telling the truth. A hundred years ago… Duncan Abnomar had indeed been a member of the Explorer Association, and even one of the most famous Explorers of that era.

Strictly speaking, the Explorer Association had not even removed this ghost captain from their rolls yet—because no one had ever thought to file the paperwork to deregister a Subspace Shadow…

Duncan did not care about Lawrence's reaction or the conflict on his face. Once he saw that Lawrence had relaxed a little, he casually chatted in a tone like small talk: "Was the trip here smooth?"

"Uh… smooth," Lawrence answered honestly, trying his best to act normal. "We set off from Frostholm's East Harbor and passed through the blockade line the Sea Mist Fleet set on the outer sea. They guided us through…"

"Mm. I told Tyrian, so the Sea Mist Fleet wouldn't trouble you," Duncan said with a nod. Then he looked up at the nearby flagpole. "Is that Anomaly 077 hanging up there?"

"Y-yes."

"What did he do wrong? Why is he hanging from the flagpole?"

Lawrence: "…"

He hesitated for several seconds before twitching the corner of his mouth: "He asked to be hung there himself. He wanted to use this to return to a sealed state, but it doesn't seem to be working very well."

"…Why are all the humanoid Anomalies I meet so strange?" Duncan muttered. He turned his head to glance at Alice, who followed behind him looking graceful and proper but in fact was off in her own world. Then he pointed at the mummified corpse hanging in midair: "Come down."

As soon as he finished speaking, the mummified corpse that had been playing dead a moment ago shook once, fell onto the deck with a bang, then tumbled and scrambled to Duncan's feet. He shook all over like Frankenstein touching electricity for the first time: "C-captain, S-Sailor r-reporting to you!"

Duncan frowned: "Are you a stutterer?"

"I-I am Sailor…"

Seeing his reaction, Duncan actually found it funny. He had not expected a sapient Anomaly ranked in the top hundred to fear Captain Duncan this much. Then Duncan turned his head in puzzlement to look back at Alice behind him.

They were both top-hundred Anomalies with minds like humans. So why did this Doll not know fear? Back then, she had only been nervous for a moment on the Vanished, then quickly adapted to the ship. Now she could even bicker with the pots and pans on board.

Alice noticed the captain's gaze and answered at once with a bright, almost solidly stupid smile.

Duncan: "…"

He suddenly felt that Alice might not have adapted quickly at all. She was just slow to react. She had probably been scared at first and then simply forgotten about being afraid…

At the same time, Alice also noticed the mummified corpse standing opposite her and shivering. She thought very hard, as if finally recalling what the captain had told her before they left. Her face lit with a smile and she greeted him first: "Hello, my name is Alice. I heard you're an Anomaly too?"

The mummified corpse froze for a moment and looked her up and down in confusion. The "elegant lady" before him looked no different from an ordinary person, yet every tiny movement felt oddly off. "You are too?"

"Yes!" Alice said happily. "My number is 099."

Sailor scratched his head awkwardly. This was probably also his first time dealing with another runaway state Anomaly like this. "Uh… I'm 077."

Alice thought for a bit and looked proud: "Then my number is bigger than yours!"

Duncan finally could not hold back: “Anomaly numbers go in order from the front. 077 comes before you.”

Alice processed that for a moment and, like a sacred miracle, actually caught up: “Ah… so that means he’s stronger than me?”

“Not necessarily. Anomalies ranked in the top hundred are all extremely bizarre. You usually can’t judge strength by numbers alone. Their dangers show up under different conditions,” Duncan explained patiently. “At sea, he should be stronger than you. On land, you are stronger than him…”

Alice did not know how much of that she understood. She only curiously watched the Sailor in front of her, then suddenly reached out and grabbed at the air.

The mummified corpse froze in place at once, as if even his soul—if he had one—had been instantly locked. Then all his joints and skin started to rapidly shift toward a Puppet-like transformation.

Alice abruptly let go.

Sailor staggered back a few steps and stared at the Doll in horror: “Wh-what the hell?”

“Not strong,” Alice shook her head. “You don’t even know how to protect your own strings.”

“Don’t go grabbing other people’s ‘strings’ without permission. Did you forget?” Duncan said sharply at once. Then he frowned. “Wait, you’re saying Anomaly 077 has strings too?”

“Yes. There are several drifting off him,” Alice said as if it were obvious. “But his strings are a little odd. An ordinary person’s strings float up high into the sky and then slowly fade. His strings float out and then curl back into his body, like they’re forming a loop…”

Duncan frowned and looked Sailor up and down, still shaken there in front of him. Then a faint green flame flashed in Alice's eyes beside him.

The next second, Duncan also saw Anomaly 077's strings—almost transparent white threads extending from the mummified corpse's skull and joints, swaying in the empty air around him and then folding back into his body.

There really were strings.

Did all sapient humanoid Anomalies have strings like this? Or was this unique to Anomaly 077? And what was going on with these strings that looped through themselves instead of rising away like an ordinary person's?

Questions flashed through Duncan's mind, but he quickly put them aside for now. He looked at Sailor and apologized seriously: "Sorry. Alice is not very sensible. She meant no harm. She just wanted to say hello."

"No, no, don't apologize!" The mummified corpse almost jumped on the spot. He hurriedly waved his hands and backed away. "I'm fine, I just got startled… Alice, right? Got it. I'll just keep my distance from her from now on…"

As he spoke, he muttered under his breath, things like "no wonder she works on the flagship" and "of course the boss's people are stronger," loud enough that even Lawrence could hear him.

Lawrence blinked and watched from the side. He had no idea what had just happened. He only felt that the two Anomalies had "communicated" somehow and that Sailor had gotten scared again. Then something occurred to him. His gaze turned odd as it fell on the beautiful lady with the elegant air. "Wait, Anomaly 099… Captain, so this is…"

"The very 'coffin' you were escorting on your ship back then," Duncan said with a smile, lifting his hand to introduce her. "But now the coffin has

already been assimilated by the Vanished. The Doll that was inside has been in a long-term runaway state, just like the Sailor next to you.”

When Alice heard that, she stepped forward at once and chattered to Duncan: “Captain, Captain, I’m not in a runaway state. I’m usually very obedient…”

“Right, right, I’m not in a runaway state either,” the mummified corpse added quickly. “I usually follow orders very well. When Captain Lawrence told me to go ashore and fight those cultists to the death, I didn’t even hesitate…”

Lawrence listened in a daze. He looked up at the Sailor trying so hard to show himself off, then at the beautiful and elegant but apparently not quite right?in?the?head “Miss from the coffin” opposite him. At last his gaze landed on Captain Duncan.

Suddenly, the pressure and tension that had been hanging over him for so long faded away. Lawrence strangely felt that he and this ghost captain before him were much closer. He even felt a kind of fellow?sufferer sympathy rise up.

It was the sympathy between two captains on the Boundless Sea who both had to take care of a runaway state Anomaly with a hole in the head…

Chapter 463: The Hybrid

Duncan strolled to the edge of the White Oak's deck and leaned out to look at the sea below.

At this moment, both the White Oak and the Vanished had withdrawn from Spirit Realm state. On the calm, blue normal sea, the water around the White Oak was clear as a mirror. The Black Oak, shrouded in fog and darkness, was reflected there like a shadow. In the dim blur of that ship's silhouette, faint lights seemed to glow.

After a long time, Duncan pulled his gaze back from the sea and spoke softly with a sigh: "An interesting phenomenon. Lawrence, you went through an incredible adventure."

"It really was… incredible," Lawrence answered respectfully and carefully from the side. "I've made a living on this sea for decades and seen many unbelievable things. But what happened at Frostholm still went far beyond all of that. No matter what though, I brought Martha back. That makes every risk worth it."

"Your wife, Martha—what state is she in now? And how exactly are these two ships you each control connected to one another?"

"She and her Black Oak are now like the shadow of the White Oak," Lawrence answered honestly. "As you can see, she is on that reflected ship. But when needed, the Black Oak can also enter the Mortal Realm as a phantom and sail alongside the White Oak, or we can perform a light?and? shadow Inversion between the two ships. In that state, we can sail deep into

the Spirit Realm and avoid obstacles in the Mortal Realm. We did that once when we crossed the war zone around Frostholm. It worked very well."

"Your wife told you all this? I mean these… techniques."

"Yes." Lawrence nodded. "Martha wandered in the mirror world spaces under the sea outside Frostholm for more than ten years. She knows many things. During our last operations, she basically served as our guide."

Duncan said nothing for a while and just watched the reflection below. After a long time, he suddenly broke the silence: "May I speak with her alone?"

Lawrence was taken aback. Surprise flickered across his face, followed at once by tension and hesitation: "This… may I ask what you…"

"Relax. I simply need to understand each of my subordinates. The Black Oak is indeed strange, but on this sea no ship is more bizarre than the Vanished. I am very tolerant in this area—as long as the Black Oak has no secrets from me."

Only then did Lawrence breathe a little easier. Though still hesitant, he nodded: "All right. I'll make arrangements and let Martha know."

Duncan gave a slight nod, then turned his head to look a short distance away.

Alice and Sailor were squatting on the deck over there. The two of them were cheerfully poking at a little bug they had caught from who knew where with small sticks. As they poked, they argued heatedly over whether the bug had a soul or not—

Alice thought it did not, because she could not see any strings on the bug. Sailor insisted that it did, because he had heard that Bartok's garden also had bugs. He even believed there were tiny Gatekeepers the size of bugs whose special job every summer was to carry the souls of dead mosquitoes

from the mortal world to the place of rest, so they could bite people who were buried in June and July…

The two of them kept bluffing each other into stunned silence.

The scene looked like two complete fools at play.

Just watching them for too long made your brain feel like it was under corruption.

Duncan quietly watched the undisturbed scene on the deck. Lawrence watched in silence beside him as well. After a long time, Duncan shook his head: “Let them play.”

“I think so too. It’s better than him hanging from the flagpole and wailing like a ghost,” Lawrence said.

…

Soon, Lawrence had his crew prepare a quiet room on the White Oak and set up a large mirror inside.

After all unrelated people left, Duncan turned around and fixed his gaze quietly on the man?tall mirror.

“I want to talk to you.” He spoke to the mirror.

The next second, the surface turned pitch black, as if thick inky liquid had suddenly flooded across it. In the depths of that darkness, a mass of swelling and shrinking Shadows slowly took shape.

A lady in a white shirt, brown vest, and long trousers stepped out of the swelling Shadows.

“Lawrence told me. You wish to speak with me alone,” the lady said as she came to the front of the mirror, answering Duncan’s gaze calmly. “It seems… you noticed.”

“Too many impurities. The overlapping shadows hide the details that do not belong to the Black Oak, but that isn’t enough to fool my flames,” Duncan said slowly. He reached out, pulled a chair over, and sat down, looking at the figure in the mirror—and at the vast darkness behind her, tangled and intricate like some illusory Veil. “How much of you is ‘Martha’?”

“…Less than one part in a thousand.”

“One in a thousand. A very small number,” Duncan said, his gaze fixed on her. The vast, chaotic “hybrid” behind her met that gaze without flinching. “Even so, you still call yourself Martha. And it looks like… you truly identify with that name.”

“Because ‘Martha’ is the only complete personality among them,” the “female adventurer” in the mirror answered. “Without a personality to support them, memories are pale pages. Flipping through them is not enough to form a ‘self’. The vast, muddled memories have been reassembled blindly and chaotically countless times. In the end, I judged that ‘Martha’ was the only ‘representative’ that could manage all of this. I need to become Martha. Martha needs to exist.”

“So you are a hybrid. And what you’ve mixed together is far more than you told Lawrence. A considerable part of the minds that fell into that sea in the past fifty years have flowed into your ‘body’. Or to put it another way… you devoured those minds?”

“Devoured… that is a very aggressive word, but I don’t see it that way. I have never devoured anything, and I am not interested in souls. It is the great power deep in that mirror world space that devours everything. The ‘memories’ that make me up are only the scraps left after that power crushed them. Tiny tributaries flow together, like motes of dust gathering into a clump. I did not exist before those fragments. Those fragments

gathered to form me—Martha—only a Ghost who woke up from the shards and belatedly took on the role of collector of the dead."

"Scraps left after being crushed…" Duncan frowned. "Why was Martha not crushed?"

"Because Lawrence came to these waters," the female adventurer in the mirror said, a faint smile on her face. "He is under your blessing. So Martha is under your blessing too."

Duncan did not reply. He fell into a long silence. After quite a while, he broke it, thoughtful: "The world in the mirror is discontinuous…"

"Yes. The world in the mirror is discontinuous. Space is not continuous, and time is not continuous either. The ending is born before the beginning. You created Martha, and now Martha is answering your questions."

Duncan let out a slow breath.

"A vast data hybrid… that explains why you know so much," he said, bringing the topic back. "It is not only because you wandered that mirror world space long enough, but because you hold enough 'memories' inside you. So back to the first question. Is less than one thousandth of 'Martha' really enough to support a stable personality and let you keep your current sense of self forever? Will there come a day when this 'collector' personality is drowned in that ocean of memories? Will you forget your own name and become a chaotic, vast, dangerous Restless Soul?"

The adventurer lifted her eyes. Behind her calm expression, she seemed to gather great courage: "Like you once were?"

"No. I went farther than you did. Subspace is far deeper and darker than the mirror world world. So I was also more dangerous back then than you are now," Duncan said. He did not mind her bold words and kept his usual calm tone. "That is why I understand very well how much harm a runaway state

Restless Soul can cause—even if this Restless Soul is a bit ‘safer’ than I was.”

The adventurer in the mirror fell silent for a moment.

After a long time, she suddenly spoke: “Do you think I can be counted as ‘Martha’ now?”

Duncan thought for several seconds.

To this vast, tangled hybrid, Martha was only one thousandth of it. But to the personality that called itself “Martha”, everything within the hybrid was her one hundred percent.

Who this huge hybrid really was and what state its future personality would settle into seemed completely “undecided”. There was a chance it would go into a runaway state, but its current personality and sense of self were also clearly real.

Duncan hesitated for a moment. As that hesitation rose, a scene that felt half real and half dreamlike suddenly surfaced in his mind—

The sea breeze was gentle, and the waves were calm.

He stood on the water. Blue waves spread out under his feet.

Fish leaped from the sea. In the bright sunlight, the fish swam through the air around him, circling at ease.

He lowered his head and looked down at his feet.

The rippling surface looked clear and transparent, yet its depths seemed veiled in mist, blurred and impossible to see through.

New things leaped from the water and swam around him.

They were fish.

Duncan woke with a start and looked at the mirror before him.

The Shadows in the mirror swelled and writhed as if waiting for an answer.

“…Lady Martha,” Duncan finally broke the silence after a long time. “Welcome to the Vanisheds Fleet.”

The formless darkness full of confusion and chaos, that mass without any clear outline, suddenly contracted. It once again became the female adventurer in a white shirt, brown vest, and long trousers.

The tangled Shadows behind her had calmed.

At the same time, on the White Oak’s deck, Lawrence, who had been acting like a temporary guardian while he watched Doll Alice and the mummified corpse Sailor poke at the bug, also looked down at his own body in confusion.

Those uncontrolled green flames that kept rising and spreading were rapidly drawing back. The body that had been stuck in Ghost form for three days straight was quickly recovering. In his senses, the Ghost fire that had been flaring up now and then for no reason seemed, for the first time, to truly become calm and turn into a part of his body he could control.

It was as if some “source of stimulus” that kept passively triggering his spirit form flames had suddenly vanished.

“…Under control?”

Lawrence blinked and muttered to himself in puzzlement.

Chapter 464: The Future of the White Oak

In Duncan’s eyes, the tangled, chaotic black shadows had once again “collapsed” into that valiant female adventurer. Deep in the mirror, the layered silhouettes no longer trembled in disorder.

Duncan watched the scene with his gaze and stayed silent for a long time.

Inside the mirror, once Martha had reformed, she stayed frozen for a moment, like a film stuck right before it officially started. After two or three seconds, a lively, human light returned to her face. She lowered her head in confusion to look at herself, then belatedly raised her head: “What… did you do?”

Duncan pulled himself out of his thoughts and shook his head lightly: “Nothing. Just welcoming you.”

He paused, sorted out his thoughts a little, then spoke: “If you are going to stay ‘Martha’ from now on, do you still plan to tell Lawrence the truth?”

“He might… already know,” Martha hesitated, then slowly said: “I once hinted at a few things with him. I told him I was built with Martha as the base and pieced together from his memories. With Lawrence’s sharp mind and his experience in the supernatural field, plus all the information I let slip that went far beyond what was needed, it shouldn’t be hard for him to guess that since ‘Martha’ can hold one set of memories, she can hold countless sets. After all…”

The female adventurer paused, a complicated smile on her face: “After all, back in that city of mirror world, I looked like I knew far too much.”

“What was his reaction?”

“He… didn’t care,” Martha shook her head. “But I don’t know if he will always not care.”

Duncan watched her quietly for a while, then suddenly laughed.

“You worry about these things. That means I really don’t need to,” he said in a relaxed tone. “So let’s set it aside, Lady. Out here on this vast sea, dark and uncanny things are countless, so every bit of warmth is worth treasuring all the more. Lawrence understands that very well.”

In the mirror, the female adventurer looked thoughtful. Outside the mirror, Duncan paused briefly, then went on: “About the Deep Sea beneath Frostholm, what else do you know?”

“The Deep Sea…” Martha frowned. She drew in her drifting thoughts, sorted through her vast store of memories, and spoke slowly: “I do have some… ‘memories’ that point to the Deep Sea, but most of them were dark and blurry, mixed with the fear of sinking without end and absurd hallucinations born in cold suffocation. These things probably can’t be used as solid reference. But…”

Duncan raised an eyebrow: “But?”

In the mirror, Martha thought for a moment, then spread her hands.

Her figure suddenly faded in the mirror, like ink bleeding in water. Black lines spread quickly across the surface. In that spreading darkness, hazy shapes began to appear.

A vast stretch of shadows floated in endless void, like a lonely island, like an irregular, jagged mass. Around that island of shadows drifted countless

tiny things, like fragments broken off from its surface, circling and orbiting it like debris.

In the center of that floating “island”, there seemed to be some huge pillar-like thing. In the dark, it extended upward and downward without end, as if it pierced straight through the shadows, then pierced through the whole void.

Martha’s voice came from deep within the mirror:

“I ran through all the memories that point to the Deep Sea. The great terror that countless devoured minds felt as they sank was stacked together into this scene. I don’t know how to interpret it. It looks like a large floating object in the Deep Sea, pierced through by a giant ‘pillar’. But without anything to compare it to, I don’t know how big that thing is, or how big that pillar is.”

Duncan stared for a long time with his gaze at the image in the mirror and did not speak.

In his mind rose all kinds of information about the Abyssal Trench Project —the submersibles that never came back, the Deep Dive vanguard teams that went mad, the insane reports of the trench beneath the sea, and the great Hollow deep inside the Boiling Gold mine, along with that tentacle of the Elder Gods that crossed the boundary between real and unreal and stabbed deep into the city-state of Frostholm.

There really was an entity in the Deep Sea.

The illusion in the mirror faded, and Martha’s figure appeared before Duncan again: “That’s all I know. I keep many memories, but very few of them point toward the Deep Sea while I am still relatively clear-headed. You…”

“It’s all right, Lady,” Duncan said softly, cutting off the female adventurer. “I will go see it for myself.”

…

On the deck, Alice and the mummified corpse “sailor” had already found a second little bug. The two “people” were still poking at it.

But this game clearly was not as fun as fighting with the pots and pans in the kitchen.

“I’m starting to feel bored,” Alice threw away the little stick in her hand and looked up at the deck, which still felt quite unfamiliar to her. “Why isn’t the captain back yet…”

The “sailor” clearly shivered when he heard the doll Miss mention the word “captain”. He lifted his head, opened his mouth, hesitated for a long time, and finally spoke: “When you usually stay with him… you’re not scared?”

“Not scared at all,” Alice turned her head and looked at the ugly mummified corpse with a puzzled face. “I like being with the captain. Why would I be scared of him?”

“That’s Subspace! Do you understand Subspace?” The mummified corpse’s expression was full of horror. “Just looking at him once, I feel like my sanity is going to ‘fall’ off. And you dare cling to him all day. I think you’re the one who should be numbered 077. You’re way more freakish than me.”

Alice scratched her hair, did not bother with the mummified corpse, and instead looked curiously toward Lawrence in the distance.

Lawrence was standing with his first mate, Gus.

“Suddenly, everyone can control the flames on their bodies,” First Mate Gus opened his palm and showed his captain a small, quietly dancing flame. Where the flame touched his skin, his flesh had turned faintly

transparent, like a spirit form. Outside the flame's edge, it was still normal flesh and blood. "Do you have any idea why?"

"I'm not sure either," Lawrence frowned a little. He snapped his fingers and watched a spirit flame jump at his fingertip. Then he waved his hand, and the flame went out without a sound. "The change started not long after Captain Duncan boarded… so it might be connected to him."

"Maybe… but either way, it's a good thing," First Mate Gus said. "Before, the flames on us would pop out of nowhere, like something had set them off, and we never found the cause. Honestly, it kept everyone on edge. Some people even worried that we might never be able to act normally on land again. After all, not every city has seen as much as Frostholm and Pland…"

"The future…" Lawrence's voice held a hint of emotion and thought. He unconsciously clenched his fist and opened it again, feeling the Power of Flame flow calmly in his body while he thought about his own future and that of the whole crew of the White Oak. "It really is time to think about the future…"

He lowered his head and rubbed his fingers together. spirit flame flowed like water between his fingertips.

A deep, stern voice came from behind him: "Having fun?"

Lawrence and Gus both shivered on the spot. Flames shot two or three meters high from their bodies…

A second later, Lawrence hurried to press down the flames on himself and turned toward the sound. Duncan was standing there, looking at them with a strange expression.

Duncan let out a quiet sigh.

The moment he came out, he saw Anomaly 077 and Anomaly 099 squatting on the deck poking bugs. Then he saw the captain and first mate of his new subordinate ship playing with fire in the doorway. If you knew this was the Vanished Fleet, fine. If you didn't, you would think this ship was heading for a kindergarten… Just what kind of people had gathered around him?

"C-Captain Duncan!" Gus snapped to attention at once. While slapping away the last sparks on his coat, he spoke in a panic: "We… we were studying how to control the Power of Flame, to stop anything like what happened in Frostholm from happening again…"

"The same kind of thing? You mean a captain leading a whole marine squad and getting arrested by the local constable, and then I had to send my envoy to the security bureau to bail them out?" Duncan pressed his fingers to his temple and waved his hand. "Forget it. As long as you're happy…"

As he spoke, Alice had already run over. She grabbed his arm and shook it hard while shouting: "Captain! You finally came back! You finished your work?"

"It's finished, it's finished—stop shaking, or you'll yank one of your joints off again," Duncan said as he held down the overexcited doll Miss. Then his gaze fell on Lawrence, and he nodded lightly. "Don't worry. Martha is doing very well. I have officially accepted her as a member of the Vanished Fleet."

Lawrence froze for a moment, then sensed the weight and deeper meaning in Duncan's words.

"You… saw that she actually…"

"You don't want to care, and she doesn't need to care. As for me… I don't mind," there was a faint smile in Duncan's eyes as he said calmly: "The

Boundless Sea is very wide. The Vanished Fleet has always dealt with all kinds of strange things. One more harmless ghost ship is nothing.”

Lawrence opened his mouth but could not say anything. In the end, he just drew in a slow breath and bowed deeply in front of Duncan.

“In any case, welcome to my fleet,” Duncan laughed and patted Lawrence’s shoulder. “Speaking of that, I think I heard you talking about… the future just now? Do you have any plans?”

“The future…” Lawrence hesitated, a complicated look on his face. “I really have been thinking about it. Do you think… we can still return to a normal harbor like before?”

Hearing the hesitation and struggle in Lawrence’s voice, Duncan sighed softly.

The future of the White Oak… really was a problem.

—

Chapter 465: A Pass?

The future of every crew member of the White Oak.

This problem, which everyone had always avoided, had finally been laid on the table.

There was no wall in the world that never leaked wind, and Frostholm was not a city-state sealed off from the outside world. The anomalous changes of the White Oak itself—especially its reflection on the surface of the sea—could not possibly stay hidden from other captains and from the harbor's eyes.

Even without that most special identity of "member of the Vanished Fleet", the ship was already a "ghost ship" wrapped in supernatural power and stuck in a strange state.

The city-states had always used the strictest safety standards for ships and crews that entered the Boundless Sea. A ship that went missing for just a short time at sea had to go through extremely strict quarantine and inspection when it returned. Even a small anomaly could get it refused at the harbor gate. There was no need to even mention a ship that had already turned into an "supernatural object".

It was likely that, besides Pland and Frostholm, no other city-state would dare accept the White Oak as it was now.

What was more, the Master of the Vanished might not even allow his own "servants" to leave the fleet and continue acting freely in the civilized

world. On that basis, what kind of future could the White Oak and her crew have?

To live side by side with anomalies, to survive in Visions, far from the civilized world, wandering in the depths of mists, storms, strange realms, and eerie sea zones. By day, to sweep across the sea like ghosts; by night, to sink into the cracks of Subspace. After all, that was how the books described the Vanished.

Lawrence looked deeply worried. Even after drifting on the Boundless Sea for most of his life, he still did not seem ready for such a change.

After all, he was not “Captain Duncan”, who had long left the civilized world behind, nor was he like Tyrian, a pirate lord who ruled a sea region with a whole fleet. He had a ship full of seafarers, and each of them had their own family and friends. They all had families to support.

If he left the legal routes on the Boundless Sea, he had no idea how he was supposed to feed his sailors, let alone how he would face their loved ones. After all, the Vanished Fleet did not seem to have things like “wages”, much less any proper employee care system…

After a short moment of thought, Duncan broke the silence: “Honestly, even without your ties to the Vanished Fleet, and without the distorted reflection from the Black Oak, your business would not have gone that well in the future anyway…”

Lawrence did not react at first: “Huh? Why do you say that?”

Duncan spread his hands: “Think about Anomaly 099 before, and then think about Anomaly 077 now…”

Lawrence’s face stiffened at once. After holding it in for a long time, he finally managed to squeeze out a sentence with an odd expression: “Occasional cargo loss is an unavoidable risk. The White Oak carries high-

premium insurance, enough to cover the employer's losses and any later liquidated damages…"

"Marine insurers now dare to cover even that?" Duncan raised his eyebrows. "Then you really don't need to worry about those two cases of lost cargo…"

He paused, then seemed to think of something: "Wait. How much do they pay if you run into the Vanished? And if you get transformed into part of the Vanished Fleet, how much do they pay then?"

"For that, there is no payment. It counts as 'force majeure'. In fact, that earlier Anomaly 099 runaway state incident was also in the excluded category, because the loss of the doll's spirit coffin was tied to the Vanished. Later I went to…" Lawrence's voice trailed off. His expression turned a bit blank, as if he had not expected Captain Duncan to suddenly bring this up. Then he finally reacted: "Why… are you asking this?"

The moment Duncan heard the words "no payment", disappointment appeared on his face. He waved his hand: "Nothing. I was just asking."

Lawrence thought for a moment. About seventy or eighty classic insurance fraud cases flashed through his mind, and he decided to keep his mouth shut.

Duncan stayed quiet for a few seconds, then changed the topic: "Besides, you might not need to worry that much about the White Oak's future. Even as part of the Vanished Fleet, you might not have to leave legal routes and legal harbors forever."

This time Lawrence was truly surprised. He stared at Duncan in confusion, as if he had no idea what this "Subspace Shadow" was getting at.

Duncan looked at him with a half-smile: "Do you think the Vanished will stay away from the civilized world forever?"

“You mean…”

Duncan smiled: “I have reclaimed my human nature. You should have heard that rumor. Since I have human nature, of course I will grow interested in the civilized world again. These past days, I have been actively in contact with the city-states of the civilized world. First Pland, then Frostholm. Along the way I also met with the Deep Sea Church and the Church of Death. To be fair, I think I’ve done quite well.”

Lawrence instinctively recalled all the events that had unfolded during this “homecoming voyage” of the Vanished, and his expression slowly turned strange.

Duncan saw the change on his face. The corner of his eye twitched, and he worked to keep his expression and tone steady: “Of course, I admit the commotion during those meetings might have been a bit much.”

Lawrence: “…”

“That’s not important,” Duncan waved his hand. “What matters is that the Vanished Fleet will become part of civilization again. You and your crew might be the bridge that lets the Vanished build further ties with the civilized city-states.”

Lawrence understood Duncan’s intent, and surprise flashed in his eyes—this way of doing things did not sound much like the stories in the books.

But he quickly woke up from that brief surprise, and more down-to-earth worries rose up: “I understand. You want to ‘normalize’ relations with the city-states, so the first step is to let us ‘fleet members’ return to normal routes. But… you’ve seen the White Oak as she is now. Most city-states probably won’t accept a ship that has been tainted by supernatural power…”

“But as far as I know, some ‘mutated’ ships are exceptions. The city-states and the legal routes still allow them to dock and pass.”

“…Huh?” Lawrence blurted.

“The Sea Mist and the Radiant Star. The level of supernatural mutation on those two ships is almost second only to the Vanished. Yet the first has already become the new flagship of the Frostholm navy, and the second is an honorary member of the Explorer Association, with unlimited passage rights on the border routes,” Duncan spread his hands. “I’ve also heard of some other famous legendary exploration ships. supernatural power corrupted and remade them, so they carry strange and terrifying traits. But their captains hold certain special papers and have powerful groups backing them, so they can still sail on the Boundless Sea.”

He paused there, then went on in a very serious tone: “Strictly speaking, every ‘Cathedral ark’ of the Four Gods’ Church is also a ship that has been altered by supernatural power. Yet they still sail wherever they like. That proves that when it comes to ‘supernatural mutation’, the standards of the Church and the city-states are very flexible.”

Lawrence was stunned by this string of words and almost got swept along by the logic. Fortunately, when he heard “Four Gods’ Church” at the end, he snapped back to his senses, and his expression grew complicated: “The Cathedral arks really can’t be treated the same. They are under the gods’ protection. That’s different… But in those other cases, things are indeed like you said. There are exceptions.”

The old captain licked his dry lips and tried to find the right words: “But exceptions are called exceptions because they are hard to get. Your two children spent half a century getting the world to slowly accept them. Even now, many city-states still treat the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star with

caution, or even hostility. As for the other legendary exploration ships you mentioned…

“Sigh, of course I know them. The Tulip, which was lost in the Spirit Realm for twelve years, and the Dust Song, which once crossed the Sea of Visions and returned with all hands alive… They did return to the civilized world, but the process of being accepted was no easier than what your two children went through.

“Extremely strict inspections, years of surveillance, the Church’s recognition. The Four Gods’ Church uses the highest safety standards to decide whether a ship that went through ‘supernatural mutation’ is safe. The harshness and difficulty of that process are beyond imagination. Even after going through all the tests, those legendary exploration ships stay under Church monitoring forever, and every so often they have to be inspected again. The passes in those legendary captains’ hands… are not easy to get.”

By the time he finished, Lawrence could not help letting out a long sigh. Duncan, however, had already gone thoughtful halfway through. When Lawrence stopped, Duncan asked with interest: “So in short, it’s enough if a Church is willing to act as guarantor? What are the requirements for this pass?”

“In short, the ‘guardian god’ behind the faction that owns the ship has to grant recognition. The White Oak belongs to the Explorer Association, and the Explorer Association is under the protection of the Deep Sea Church. Storm Goddess Gamona is the protector of explorers at sea. So if the White Oak wants to return to legal routes, at least one Saint of the Deep Sea has to be willing to swear an oath before the Goddess to act as guarantor, and, after receiving an oracle, personally carry out the inspection on the ship in question. In the end, an inquisitor from a city-state issues the pass.”

At this point, Lawrence sighed again: “Strictly speaking, that ‘Gatekeeper’ Lady Agatha would actually meet the identity requirements. She is both a Saint and the city’s ‘Gatekeeper’, and because of a series of events, she became your envoy. Sadly… she doesn’t belong to the Deep Sea Church…”

Duncan looked at him: “I have a Saint of the Deep Sea Church too.”

“…Huh?” Lawrence stared.

“A Saint of the Deep Sea Church, right?” Duncan looked very seriously at the worried Lawrence. “The Saint does the inspection, and the inquisitor signs the pass. Can the Saint and the inquisitor be the same person?”

Lawrence suddenly felt his brain jam. He answered on pure reflex: “I don’t think… there’s any rule against that…”

“Oh. Then go take care of your own business. I’ll go ask about the pass for you.”

Lawrence blinked and still did not quite react.

By the time he thought to ask a question, Duncan’s figure had already vanished from the deck in a pillar of flame that shot into the sky.

Chapter 466: Summons

“That’s how things stand, Vanna. What do you think?”

On the deck of the Vanished, Duncan spoke to Vanna, who was carving a charm amulet out of a piece of Sea-Breath Wood.

Vanna listened in a daze as Duncan passed on the problems the White Oak now faced and the captain’s plans for the future. It took her a long moment to react. She tossed the newly carved charm amulet into the wooden bucket, lifted her head, and said: “You mean I should vouch for the White Oak as the Saint, and then, as an Inquisitor, issue a pass that allows an aberrant ship to regain legal status?”

“It seems workable on paper,” Duncan said with a serious face. “After all, you really are the Saint of the Storm Goddess, and you’re still the Inquisitor of Pland.”

“But my Inquisitor post has already been revoked…”

Duncan waved his hand: “Wasn’t that something your Pope arranged in private? Your official status in public hasn’t changed.”

Vanna froze again. This straightforward lady still was not used to Duncan’s way of thinking. The idea of “picking loopholes in the rules” was something she had never even considered in all her years as an Inquisitor. She instinctively felt that something about it was wrong, but she could not say what. She could only speak in hesitation: “The procedure… I don’t even know if the procedure is proper, but…”

Duncan cut off Vanna’s hesitation with a solemn look: “The White Oak needs to regain legal status. The Vanished Fleet needs to reconnect with the civilized world. You don’t want us to remain shadows hanging over the world forever. Turning the Vanished Fleet, which once threatened the world, into something harmless is a good thing. And as the Saint of the Storm Goddess, you should be the one to push this forward. Don’t you think so?”

Vanna froze. Her expression grew calm as she sank into thought. After a long time, she raised her head and looked into Duncan’s eyes: “You sound just like you do when you’re fooling Alice.”

“But you are not Alice—Alice believed me as soon as I said the first sentence.”

Vanna: “…”

“But the reasoning is the same. The White Oak really does need your help now,” Duncan went on calmly. “And from a practical point of view, having one more controllable and powerful extraordinary exploration vessel is not a bad thing for the city-states. It’s better than letting this ship truly become a wandering shadow on the Boundless Sea.”

“I…”

Vanna opened her mouth, as if about to say something, when a faint, distant chime suddenly rang in her mind and cut her off.

She lifted her head and, by instinct, began the Listening Rite, turning toward the direction the bell came from. The bell’s special rhythm seemed to echo inside her soul, while Duncan’s worried voice sounded as if it came from the far side of some heavy Veil: “What happened?”

“The swift bell… the Great Cathedral is summoning Saints from everywhere. It sounds like news about the Nameless King’s tomb…” Vanna

muttered in confusion, her tone tinged with disbelief. “Why can I still hear this summons…”

Duncan raised his eyebrows: “Is that strange? You’re still the Saint of the Deep Sea Church.”

“But I thought…” Vanna frowned. “I thought once I boarded the Vanished, they wouldn’t summon me again.”

Duncan’s eye twitched. From her tone he could hear that “getting on this ship” sounded a lot like “boarding a pirate ship.” But he quickly smoothed his expression and said calmly: “Don’t overthink it. Since it’s a summons from the Great Cathedral, go to the prayer room at once. And if you get the chance to meet Pope Helena, ask her about issuing a pass for the White Oak.”

A strange look flashed across Vanna’s face, but this time she managed to hold back her questions. With the bell in her mind tolling again and again like an urgent knock, she gave Duncan a quick nod, then turned and hurried toward the cabin.

There were many empty cabins on the Vanished. With the captain’s permission, she had already turned one of them into a prayer room. She had never tried it before, but in theory she should be able to answer psychic communications there and travel to the “assembly ground.”

Vanna left. Duncan did not look away until her figure vanished behind the cabin door.

He stared a moment longer at the direction Vanna had gone, then turned his head to glance at Alice, who had come back to the Vanished with him and was now dragging a big water bucket not far away, getting ready to scrub the deck. After a long pause, he sighed softly: “Sigh… so much harder to talk her around.”

After he sighed, he bent down and picked up the Sea-Breath Wood charm amulet that Vanna had carved, which lay in the bucket beside him.

The charm amulet was not very exquisite, but it was made with care. Duncan stood at the edge of the deck, idly playing with the small wooden piece as he waited for Vanna to return.

In theory, it should not take long.

As he waited with nothing else to do, he slowly sorted through the information from this period, especially what he had just learned aboard the White Oak.

The vast shadows beneath the Deep Sea, the “hybrid” called Martha, and… the changes that had taken place in that hybrid.

In Duncan’s mind, he saw again the scene of that pulsing, swelling mass of shadow gathering and stabilizing back into “Martha,” and… the vision of the “fish” that had appeared before that moment.

He turned his head and looked toward the gently rolling sea in the distance.

The sea was deep, and the waves rose and fell like a curtain.

The surface of the water seemed like a Veil that hid all secrets, blocking the truth beneath. When a fishing rod was cast, no one knew what would bite the hook.

And what he had pulled up back then was a “fish.”

Duncan’s eyes grew a little more solemn. He lowered his head to look at the little wave charm amulet in his hand. After a brief pause, he tossed the amulet back into the bucket and picked up a plain, uncarved piece of wood lying nearby.

He stared at the wood very seriously. After a long time, he spoke in a slow and solemn tone: “This is a piece of bread.”

The wood was still wood. Nothing changed.

Duncan stared at the piece of wood for quite a while, then tugged at the corner of his mouth. He lifted his head to make sure no one was around, then casually tossed the wood back where it had been.

“Looks like it’s not that simple… so what is the principle behind it, anyway…”

…

At the same time, in a private cabin beneath the deck of the Vanished, Vanna had already finished setting up the space for the ritual.

She locked the cabin door, then turned to look at the ritual field she had prepared.

Under normal conditions, answering the assembly summons required using the special “tide chamber” built inside the Cathedral to construct a psychic channel. On a ship with such limited conditions, that was obviously not realistic. So she had to place her usual prayer books on the floor nearby to serve as anchors for the “holy ground,” light a large candelabrum in the center of the room to act as the ritual brazier, then dig out the holy oil and incense she had bought in the city-states to serve as “sacrificial offerings” that would boost the ritual. It barely added up to the elements needed to open a psychic channel.

To be honest, the setup was very rough, even a little disrespectful to the Goddess—but there was no better option.

The bell in her mind kept ringing, echoing again and again like a constant urge, as if it would keep tolling forever if she did not answer.

“…I hope the Goddess won’t blame me for this… If I’d known, I should at least have prepared some better-quality holy oil.”

Vanna muttered under her breath, then finally made up her mind. She took the holy oil and the incense and let a few drops fall into the candelabrum.

As the flames suddenly leapt higher, she drew in a soft breath and let her mind sink into calm…

It was as if an ancient dark sky hung over a vast assembly ground. Chaotic streams of light flowed and flickered at the tops of countless old and solemn pillars. On the broken plaza between the pillars, one hazy figure after another began to appear.

Only after all the other figures had taken their places did Vanna's spirit projection arrive, a little late.

A slight dizziness and the feeling of her senses being peeled away made her stand in place for a few seconds. Once she had roughly adjusted, she lowered her head to check her own condition and the outlines of the figures around her.

"It actually went fairly smoothly…"

She muttered in some surprise.

She had not used a tide chamber. She had performed the ritual with only a makeshift altar on the Vanished and a candle standing in for the ritual brazier. She had not expected this method to have a high chance of success, yet it had worked on the first try.

A figure came up beside her, cutting off Vanna's thoughts.

She lifted her head. From the familiar outline and presence, she recognized who it was—Bishop Valentine, whom she had not seen for a long time.

"Vanna, you finally made it!" The old Bishop's voice held the joy of a long-awaited reunion. "I didn't think you would really be able to come…"

“I also… didn’t expect it,” Vanna said, a little embarrassed. “Have you all been waiting long? Conditions here are limited. I had to prepare the ritual in a hurry. It took a long time…”

“It’s all right. For some reason, Her Eminence the Pope is also very late today. She still hasn’t arrived,” Valentine said at once. Then he leaned closer and lowered his voice: “Where are you now? Still ‘on the ship’?”

“…Yes, on the ship. I just left Frostholm,” Vanna replied. She glanced around and also lowered her voice. “I was talking with the ‘captain’ only ten minutes ago.”

“…He actually let you set up a prayer room on the ship?” Bishop Valentine sounded deeply amazed. “And you can even open a psychic channel from there? Did you find a powerful sacred relic?”

“It’s just a simple ritual field,” Vanna said, a bit embarrassed. “I didn’t think it would work either…”

“A simple ritual field?” Valentine said in puzzlement. But before he could go on, a rumble rose from the center of the plaza and cut him off.

With a deep booming sound, the ancient and solemn tomb of the Nameless King slowly rose from the center of the plaza. The Saints gathered all over the assembly ground fell silent in turn, and one gaze after another fixed on the gray-white pyramid-shaped structure.

Vanna also looked up at the structure, at the heavy gate before the pyramid.

The gate slowly opened, and the Tomb Guardian stepped out, wrapped in bandages and seeming to exist somewhere between life and death.

Vanna felt a jolt in her heart, then saw the tall guardian walk straight toward her.

A small stir swept through the assembly ground.

This was the third time in a row that the Tomb Guardian had chosen the same Listener.

Yet for some reason, Vanna felt a strange sense of… acceptance, almost as if she had expected this. She turned her head, spread her hands helplessly at Valentine’s shadowy figure, then stepped forward to wait for the guardian to approach.

The giant being, caught between life and death, strode up to Vanna and lowered his gaze from his clouded yellow eyes.

“Good afternoon. Please follow me.”

Chapter 467: The Guard’s Secret

The Tomb Guardian’s manner was even more courteous than last time—almost respectful.

Vanna could clearly feel the change in the air around her and the puzzled looks from her fellow Saints. Yet even she had no idea how to explain this strange change. Even if vague guesses rose in her mind, she had no way to put them into words.

She could only lower her head and look at the parchment sheet the giant guardian held out to her. After hesitating for two seconds, she reached out to take it and drew a quiet breath.

“I’ll be right back.” She turned her head and said this quickly to Bishop Valentine, then followed the giant guardian of the tomb, walking toward the pale building not far away.

The heavy stone gate slowly closed behind them, sealing the ancient and mysterious tomb once more. The giant guardian of the tomb did not vanish. Instead, like a proper guide, he walked beside Vanna and led her toward the deeper layers of the tomb. In the long, shadowy corridor, the steady sound of their footsteps only made the silence around them seem deeper.

Vanna silently recited all the taboos she had to remember after entering Vision 004, while carefully watching the Tomb Guardian’s movements. She recalled how this guardian had acted the last time before she entered the tomb chamber, and thoughts churned restlessly in her mind.

Because of the limits of Vision 004, she could no longer remember what had happened after she entered the tomb last time. But she still remembered that even before she had gone in, the guardian's attitude had already changed in a subtle way. Back then, she had not thought about it too deeply. This time, however, all kinds of connections spread through her mind against her will.

While Vanna's thoughts rose and fell, a low, hoarse voice suddenly reached her ears—the giant guardian had broken the silence.

"Do you have anything you wish to ask?"

Vanna's heart gave a jolt. This silent and terrifying guardian was actively speaking to the Listener entering the tomb?!

In her mind, she quickly ran through all the information about Vision 004 again, checking the various taboos to see how she should deal with this situation. Then she forced herself to calm down and, choosing her words carefully, asked: "You treat me very kindly. Why?"

"Because you are an Envoy," the Tomb Guardian answered at once. "Envoys are those who have transcended and ascended. They deserve courtesy."

"Envoy?" Vanna was stunned, not quite understanding. "What does that mean? Do you mean I'm the Saint of the Storm Goddess Gamona? But everyone out there on the plaza is…"

"The Leviathan Queen has no Envoy. All of her Envoys died before the first Long Night," the Tomb Guardian cut in before Vanna could finish. His voice held almost no trace of emotion. Even when he spoke of a deity, there was neither reverence nor fear. "You are the Envoy of the Flame Usurper."

Her heart tightened all at once. Her head rang with a sudden roar, and even her breath stopped without her noticing. Vanna halted in shock. The answer

to her casual question went far beyond anything she had imagined. It felt as if a storm had swept through her mind, and in its wake came crashing waves of guesses, realizations, and shifting understanding.

The Leviathan Queen—she remembered that title. Not long ago, Captain Duncan had mentioned that name in front of her and Morris!

Long Night—she remembered that term too. After reading The Blasphemous Tome, Mr. Morris had said that it used “Long Night” several times to describe the Elder Kings’ attempts to create the world in the Age of Antiquity. She remembered that in those heretical descriptions there were three Long Nights, and three Genesis Protocols as well!

As for the Flame Usurper…

“The Flame Usurper… does that mean Captain Duncan?” A thought flashed through Vanna’s mind, and she spoke without thinking.

Inside Vision 004, one could not casually speak of the master of the tomb or the secrets within it. But the taboos said nothing about talking about the outside world. Vanna gathered her courage and questioned the Tomb Guardian in front of her. Some inner instinct also told her that even if she asked this guardian a few more questions, it would not bring her danger.

Yet this time the guardian did not answer at once. After several seconds of silence, he slowly turned his head and looked into Vanna’s eyes.

“After you leave, you will still forget the secrets you learn here. Asking too much is pointless.”

Vanna froze. It felt as if a bucket of cold water had been poured over the curiosity blazing in her heart.

Of course. Most of the information inside Vision 004 could not be taken outside. No matter how much she learned here, she would still forget it once she left.

Even if she wrote it on the parchment sheet, anything that should not be revealed would still be torn away in the end.

She did not dare ask the guardian what the “forgetting mechanism” of Vision 004 actually was. That already pointed to the tomb itself, and asking it would bring trouble.

She could only sigh, step forward in regret, and keep walking toward the deepest chamber.

But just then, she heard the guardian’s voice again in her ears—

“The Flame Usurper’s name is not Duncan.”

Vanna’s eyes opened wider. She did not have time to wonder why the Tomb Guardian was suddenly willing to answer her earlier question. She blurted out: “Then what about the Leviathan Queen? From what you said, she’s the storm…”

But the Tomb Guardian suddenly stopped walking and cut her off in a low voice: “We are here.”

Vanna lifted her head and saw that the long, deep corridor had somehow already reached its end. The door to the central chamber now stood right in front of her. Pale firelight flickered inside the tomb, as if urging her to hurry in.

A second later, she understood: she could no longer ask more questions.

Even with this strange, inexplicable identity of “Envoy” on her, the Tomb Guardian’s courtesy toward her had its limits—or rather, the questions the guardian himself could answer were limited.

She did not know whether those limits lay in the number of questions or in the scope of what he could answer. Sadly, once she left Vision 004, all her

memories would be wiped clean. She would probably never have a chance to test this with repeated experiments.

A few messy thoughts flashed through Vanna’s mind. In the end, she just let out a quiet breath and thanked the guardian softly: “Thank you for your patience.”

“Please go in. Afterward, I will send you back out—though you will not remember.”

Vanna nodded and stepped into the chamber. As she crossed the doorway, the bandage-wrapped guardian, caught between life and death, vanished silently from the corridor.

On the ancient and solemn throne, the headless Nameless King sat in silence as if he had never moved since ancient times. A pale brazier burned steadily in the corner of the tomb, and the air was filled with a quiet, grave presence.

Vanna came to stand before the throne and saw that the place set aside for the Listener now held a very comfortable-looking chair with a back. There was also a table in front of the chair.

On the table sat a fruit plate and pastries, and even a cup of black tea—still steaming.

Vanna: “…”

She forced herself to keep her expression in check and sat down in the chair as calmly as she could.

Though a Listener could not carry memories of the tomb to the outside world, she was sure that under normal circumstances no one who entered this chamber received such treatment!

In the bits of information that sometimes came out with the parchment sheets, there had been descriptions of the Listening Rite. Not one of them mentioned fruit plates and pastries!

After a brief daze and a strong urge to complain, Vanna quickly calmed down, and her eyes grew serious.

She looked around.

Inside Vision 004, there was only pale, cold stone. In theory, there was no place to store food and no way to have a kitchen. The Tomb Guardian might know how to brew tea, but she simply could not imagine that giant baking pastries.

She studied the items on the table.

The fruit was fresh, the tea was steaming, and the pastries sat on a fine silver-inlaid wooden tray. The patterns on it faintly carried the style of the southern city-states, very much like the crafts of Elven city-states such as Lightwind Harbor or Southport.

Vanna picked up a biscuit and felt the warmth still lingering in it.

Perhaps an hour ago, it had still been in the oven of some pastry shop in some city-state.

So… had the Tomb Guardian brought these things directly from some southern city-state? Could he enter the Mortal Realm in person? Or were there secret worshippers in the Mortal Realm who followed the Tomb Guardian’s orders and offered “sacrificial rites” to Vision 004?

The fruit and the tray holding the pastries both looked like southern specialties. That region was Elven territory. The Elves… this mysterious, long-lived race did indeed keep many unique faith practices. Some of those beliefs were completely different from the Four Gods Church of today and had become systems of their own…

Could there be explanations of Vision 004 hidden in the Elves' ancient texts?

Thoughts rose and fell in Vanna's mind. Her professional habits pushed her to dig into every "unusual" thing she saw.

But her thoughts did not last long.

A soft scraping sound suddenly rang out in the tomb and cut off Vanna's train of thought.

She turned toward the sound and saw that the headless king was slowly lifting his arm, as if he were about to rise from the throne—

Vanna opened her eyes.

The ancient, solemn pillars of the assembly ground came into view. Dim, chaotic streams of light swept across the sky above the plaza. The Saints' spirit projections were gathering from afar, and in the corner of her eye she saw the pale, mysterious building slowly sinking back into the earth amid distant rumbling.

Had she already finished her task?

Vanna felt a little dazed. She shook her head. Her memories seemed to stop at the moment she followed the polite Tomb Guardian through the door. This feeling of a broken memory was not unfamiliar. It was not her first time entering Vision 004 as a Listener. But for some reason… this time she felt there was something odd clinging to her memory, as if…

Some discordant impressions had still left shallow traces in her wiped memory.

But soon she had no time to examine that faint sense of wrongness.

Her fellow Saints had already gathered. Bishop Valentine's projection was among them. A little farther away, she could also see the late-arriving Pope

Helena standing at the edge of the plaza, quietly watching this side.

“Vanna,” Valentine spoke first. “How do you feel? This was your third time entering the tomb. Has it affected you?”

“I…” Vanna frowned, as if she wanted to check her own mental state. But before she could sense anything clearly, she could not help letting out a burp. “Hic—”

The Saints who had gathered in concern around her fell silent all at once.

Even Bishop Valentine was stunned. The old priest, who had watched Vanna grow up, stared for a long moment before finally saying: “Did you go in there and chew on rocks?”

Chapter 468: New Visions

Bishop Valentine’s words made Vanna freeze for a moment. Then she did not know how to reply at all.

Noticing that the mood in the room turned a bit strange, Valentine also felt a little awkward. He looked at Vanna with a helpless expression and said: “The main thing is… people who come out of Vision 004 have all kinds of reactions. Some are dizzy, some have short-term mental problems, some even show Cognitive Shift. I can understand all that—but you are the first one to come out while burping.”

Vanna felt the atmosphere around her grow more and more odd. She herself did not know what to do: “I don’t even know how to respon—hic!”

She hurriedly swallowed, forcing down the urge to burp again. At the same time she tried, confused and anxious, to think about what had really happened after she entered Vision 004. Just then, the Saint projections who had gathered around them suddenly stirred. A moment later, they all moved aside.

Pope Helena walked through the crowd and stopped in front of Vanna.

The appearance of Your Eminence made Vanna straighten her back at once. She raised her head, and instinctively wanted to salute—but failed to hold it in and let out another burp.

Helena frowned.

This elegant and dignified Lady stared at Vanna in puzzlement for a while. Then Helena raised her head and looked at the empty ground where the “tomb of the Nameless King” had just sunk back into the earth. She watched that spot for a long time before turning her gaze back to Vanna: “…Did you eat the Tomb Guardian?”

“…?”

Vanna stared in shock for several seconds before she finally spoke in a helpless tone: “It would make more sense if you suspected I was in there gnawing on stones…”

There was not the slightest change on Helena’s face. It was as if, in her eyes, Vanna—this Inquisitor who was shocking even in the full history of the Deep Sea Church—really could pull off something as insane as swallowing a Tomb Guardian whole. But soon Helena shook her head. She calmed her voice and said: “True, even for you, that would be a bit extreme. So… what actually happened?”

“I don’t remember, I…” Vanna shook her head. Yet the moment she spoke, it felt as if a vague image rose in her mind—like a blocked-off memory trying to float to the surface. But that image vanished in the blink of an eye. Vanna frowned in confusion for a while and in the end could only keep shaking her head. “I’m sorry. I really don’t remember.”

“Is that so… It seems that even entering Vision 004 three times in a row still cannot resist this kind of Memory Erasure,” Helena said, her expression unchanged. Her gaze fell on Vanna’s hand. “Then let us confirm the parchment sheet. See what message you brought out this time.”

The Pope’s reminder made Vanna suddenly remember the important matter. She quickly pushed aside the messy thoughts and the embarrassment in her head and took out the parchment sheet she had been gripping so tightly.

As always, more than half of the parchment sheet had already been torn away. The information that should not leave the tomb was once again left behind inside Vision 004. On the remaining small part of the sheet, several lines of messy text were written.

Vanna's eyes fell on those words, and her gaze suddenly tightened.

"…Vision-Frostholm…

"Vision-the Vanished…

"Vision-Lost Fleet…"

Three rough lines of text listed three Visions by name—without numbers.

Helena's eyes grew more and more serious.

Bishop Valentine also saw the records on the parchment sheet, and he fell into deep shock.

Once again, Vanna had brought out strange information from the tomb of the Nameless King—odd Vision codenames that were completely different from the normal "Anomaly and Visions list" format!

"Again…" Vanna herself felt shocked. She stared fixedly at the words on the parchment sheet. Only after a long time did she raise her head, looking at the Pope in front of her with confusion. "Visions without numbers."

"The appearance of Vision-Frostholm does not surprise me. After Pland turned into a Vision, I already had this feeling," Helena said in a grave tone, her eyes deep and unreadable. "But the Vanished…"

"The Vanished was already on the Visions list," Helena went on. "Now even its number has been stripped away."

"Not only that. Now the Lost Fleet has appeared too," Valentine said from the side. "It is also a numberless Vision—and it stands separate from the

Vanished, occupying its own entry!”

Helena did not speak. Instead, she lifted her head and slowly swept her gaze over the spirit projections around her.

The Saints understood at once. They were well trained in the “secrecy rules” and the risks of corruption. They did not need any extra order. One by one, they bowed to the Pope, then left the gathering place.

Soon, the vast and ancient square was empty. Only Vanna, Valentine, and Helena remained.

“What has changed on the Vanished recently?” After all the other Saints were gone, Helena finally asked, “Why did the name of the Lost Fleet suddenly appear on the list? Is Captain Duncan calling his fleet back together?”

The Lost Fleet had truly existed, but that was more than a century ago. And that fleet had never been treated as a dangerous “Vision.”

With the most advanced exploration ship of its time, the Vanished, as the flagship; the two powerful warships the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star as escorts; and more than ten different support ships of all sizes, the Lost Fleet had once been the strongest and greatest exploration fleet on the Boundless Sea. Before that terrible upheaval occurred, this glorious fleet had discovered countless islands, opened more than ten vital trade routes, and had even drawn part of the borders of the civilized world.

In that era, Captain Duncan and the Lost Fleet were not frightening symbols. Instead, they stood for honor and greatness. They were the symbol of the courage of civilization pushing toward the edges of the world.

All of that ended suddenly when the Vanished fell into Subspace.

After that, the Lost Fleet broke apart. The flagship returned to the Mortal Realm with the label “Vision 005.” Its fleet members then dissolved and

scattered during the following century. The only two remaining warships, the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star, no longer acted under the name of the Lost Fleet.

So through all this history, the “Lost Fleet” had never been listed as a Vision.

But now, a new Vision had appeared, and it was called “Lost Fleet.”

“…There is a ship named the White Oak,” Vanna said, sorting out her thoughts. She began to tell Helena about the recent incident in the Frost Sea. She knew the Pope must have her own intelligence channels and should already know the general situation in Frostholm, but only someone in the center of the incident—like Vanna—could know the details. “That ship is now a member of the Lost Fleet…”

Helena’s face stayed serious as she listened carefully to Vanna’s report on the “mirror world Frostholm incident,” and on how the White Oak was Transformed and absorbed into the Lost Fleet.

Only when Vanna finished did the female Pope break the silence: “So, a new Lost Fleet is forming. The moment that new exploration ship was Transformed into a member of the fleet, a new ‘Vision’ appeared on the tomb’s list.”

“It seems so.” Vanna nodded lightly. “Born as a Vision… and a numberless Vision at that. Something like this…”

“This kind of thing is not unheard of in history,” Helena said, shaking her head. “But every time a new Vision is born, it is usually accompanied by a huge disaster, or by huge changes in the environment of an entire region, even an entire sea. What did the birth of this Lost Fleet bring?”

Vanna opened her mouth, but her mind suddenly went blank.

“It seems… nothing happened?” she said after hesitating for a long time, almost like she was talking to herself. “At least for now, no one was hurt because of it. No place turned into a forbidden zone. In fact… the transformation of the White Oak came together with Frostholm returning to stability. The whole event seemed to develop in a good direction…”

Helena stared quietly into Vanna’s eyes. “Not only that. This new ‘Vision’ also has no ‘rules’ or ‘taboos’ we can sum up.”

A look of thought appeared on Vanna’s face.

“Normal Visions all have their rules and taboos. Just like normal Anomalies all have their dangers, and their containment and sealing conditions,” Bishop Valentine could not help speaking up. “But from what you just described, the Lost Fleet does not show any taboo-like behavior at all—not yet. Even though the White Oak has its own strange traits, these ‘strange’ things are limited to that ship itself, not to the entire ‘fleet.’”

“Maybe it is because this Vision has only just been born, so we cannot sum up its patterns yet,” Helena said, thinking. “But a greater possibility is… that it is like Pland now.”

“Pland now?” Vanna repeated the words without thinking and looked at Bishop Valentine. “Right now, Pland…”

“Just as I told you the last time we spoke: safe, calm. The veil of night is no longer frightening. The darkness no longer mutates,” Valentine said seriously. “It has been a long time since I received any report of supernatural corruption in the city. I believe Frostholm will soon become the same.”

Helena nodded slightly. “A calm veil of night and darkness, a place where life is stable and safe—this is the strangest thing in the world. The strangest thing is a place with no strangeness. Pland is such a place now.”

Vanna stayed silent and fell into quiet thought.

After a brief silence, Bishop Valentine spoke again: “Maybe all these numberless Visions will be the same. They reject all supernatural corruption except for themselves. The only strange thing they display is… that there is nothing strange within their range.”

“We still cannot jump to conclusions. At the very least, we must observe the newly appeared ‘Vision-Frostholm’ for a while,” Helena said in a deep voice. Then she frowned slightly and looked at Vanna. “So, as the one who controls all this, did Captain Duncan do anything… special? Does he have any plan? Will he keep expanding his fleet, or will he reclaim the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star into the Lost Fleet? Did he tell you anything?”

Vanna thought for a moment, and a hint of hesitation flashed across her face: “Well… he did give me a task.”

“A task for you?” Helena’s expression turned serious at once. “What task?”

“…He asked me to find a way to get a pass issued for the White Oak. To… slip it through the Church’s approval process somehow.”

“…?”

Chapter 469: Signature

Helena asked Vanna to confirm it several times, just to make sure she was not hearing things.

“So, you mean that Captain Duncan Abnomar, the Shadow of Subspace, the master of the Vanished, started to rebuild the ‘Lost Fleet’ after the Frostholm incident. And his very first step… was to have you bend the rules and get his new ship a travel pass?”

Vanna’s face showed clear embarrassment. Her voice also carried some hesitation, but she still had to nod stiffly: “Yes… that is what he told me.”

“And he wants this pass so that the new member of the Lost Fleet can keep running cargo on the Boundless Sea?”

“…Yes. That is also what he told me.”

Helena lifted her head and looked toward the spot where Vision 004 had sunk into the ground. Then she looked back at Vanna standing before her. Then she looked up again. Her gaze went back and forth several times before she finally could not hold herself back: “The tomb of the Nameless King updated the Visions list again today! Because of Duncan Abnomar’s actions, the world now has three new numberless Visions! The Churches of the Four Gods will all be busy. We may need a lot of people and a lot of time to figure out what these numberless Visions really mean—including that ‘Lost Fleet’!”

“Yes,” Vanna said with her head lowered. “But… he really hopes the Deep Sea Church can issue a special pass for the White Oak.”

Helena tilted her head back and quietly lifted her gaze to Vanna’s eyes.

Vanna kept her head bowed and tried her best to show all her embarrassment and guilt through her posture.

But her effort almost had no effect.

After all, the Pope was about one meter seventy, while Vanna was close to one meter ninety.

Helena took two careful steps back without changing her expression.

“Two things,” the Pope seemed to take a quiet breath. Her face calmed, and she once more showed her usual elegant and dignified bearing as she spoke to Vanna. “First, you are not allowed to sign this pass. Even though you still officially hold the titles of Inquisitor and Saint, you are also a member of the Vanished. That does not meet the rules about avoiding conflicts of interest, Vanna. You should understand this.”

Vanna’s face instantly showed regret and awkwardness, and she spoke without thinking: “Then the second thing…”

Helena closed her eyes slightly, as if steadying herself: “Second, I will sign the pass.”

For a moment, Vanna did not react. She stared at the female Pope with wide eyes.

Helena did not seem to care about Vanna’s sudden shock and doubt. She simply let out a slow breath and said: “So, what style of pass do you think Duncan Abnomar would like?”

Vanna kept staring, still dumbfounded.

She heard the Pope’s voice continue: “The pass will be ready soon. I will hold a Prayer in the great Storm Cathedral and perform a Listening rite for the Goddess’s revelation. If there truly is no problem, the pass will be sent

to you through an Esoteric Rite. Maintain your ritual setup over there and wait for the message."

As Helena finished speaking, her figure began to fade. In a short while, she disappeared completely from the square.

Deep in the Boundless Sea, along a secret route twisted and hidden by supernatural power, the majestic Cathedral ark sailed slowly along the borders of civilization.

The steam core pushed out powerful force. Holy steam rose above the Cathedral ark and gathered into a cloud that did not disperse. Gentle bells rang, announcing the end of a successful psychic conclave.

In the deepest part of the Cathedral ark, in the "lower hold" that was sunk into the Boundless Sea, braziers burned with bright fire. The flames drove away the darkness and shadows. Standing between two braziers, the female Pope slowly opened her eyes.

The dignified Lady took a deep breath. A complicated and tangled look crossed her face. Almost at the same time, an old and hoarse voice reached her ears: "Oh, you look troubled, young Lady."

Helena raised her head and glanced into the distance. The shaking firelight lit up that spot. There, a "pillar" made from twisted, root-like blood vessels and nerves stood in the dimness. All kinds of artificial pipes and electrodes were attached to those thick nerve bundles. Tiny lights flashed between them, flickering on and off.

"You were awake the whole time?" Helena steadied herself and politely spoke with the mythic beast.

"I did not want to be awake, but it was too noisy," said the great beast carrying the Cathedral ark on its back. "Every time you people use that psychic channel thing to meet, it is noisy. Today was especially noisy."

“…I am sorry. Some things happened, and my mind was not very calm this time,” Helena said. “Next, I need to pray and seek revelation from the Goddess.”

“You have something to discuss with the Queen?” The old, hoarse voice sounded again. “All right, I will not bother you. I hope you get a clearer answer this time. And say hello to the Queen for me.”

Helena gave a small “mm” in reply, then turned around. She faced the brazier closest to her, closed her eyes, and began to focus on her Prayer.

In the vast, dim space, silence covered everything. Time seemed to stop flowing. Only the flames in the brazier leaped and danced, as if weaving an unseen exchange that crossed the Veil.

No one knew how long passed before Helena finally finished her Prayer and slowly opened her eyes.

She frowned. This time, her Prayer felt different from usual.

The revelation sent by the Goddess… was as vague as always. But amid that hazy “guidance,” there seemed to be something mixed in that felt like… emotions.

Helena could not tell what that vague and unfamiliar feeling was. But after she lowered her head and thought for a long time, she still confirmed the main part of the revelation: it was permission and approval.

So Helena let out a breath, then turned her head and looked at that bundle of nerves covered with pipes, cables, and electrodes. “The Goddess has given Her revelation. And I passed along your greeting.”

No answer came. The Leviathan that carried the ark seemed to have fallen asleep again.

Helena was not surprised. After giving that greeting, she simply reached out and grabbed at the darkness beside her. A blank travel document appeared in her hand out of thin air.

She quickly checked to make sure she had the right form. Then the female Pope picked up a pen and signed her name and some required details with a few strokes. After that, she walked to the brazier closest to her and, lowering her head, silently recited the words of the Prayer. She placed the document into the fire.

In the blink of an eye, the document and both copies of the pass, all bearing her name, were swallowed by the flames. They turned into specks of light and scattered from the Mortal Realm.

…

Vanna opened her eyes in the ship's cabin. The moment she woke up, she started to gasp for breath.

The ritual field they had set up in a hurry was rough and simple. It was nothing like the "Tidal Chamber" inside the Cathedral. When her mind came back, the feeling of being soaked in seawater was especially strong. Even Vanna, a Saint of Storms, felt a bit uncomfortable.

Still, the psychic conclave this time was completed smoothly.

Vanna took a few deep breaths and calmed herself. She sorted through the events of the conclave in her mind, then got ready to patiently wait for Pope Helena's reply, and for the pass that was very likely to be sent to her through an Esoteric Rite.

In theory, the Pope still needed to carry out a series of Prayer rituals before the pass was ready—even if, for various reasons, they left out the step of "inspecting the ship receiving the document," they still could not skip the Goddess's benediction.

But in the next second, as Vanna’s gaze swept toward the temporary altar they had set up in a rush, her expression suddenly froze.

The thick candles serving as the ritual brazier had somehow already burned down. The candle-stand that should have burned for a full day now held only a pile of ash and wax. In the last faint wisp of smoke, a “pass document” still glowing with a soft light lay quietly on the floor.

So fast?

Vanna frowned and stepped forward in confusion. She picked up the pages and carefully looked through their contents.

It was a standard permit. It recorded the basic information about the White Oak and the supernatural factors involved. It carried the Church’s stamp. There was the main pass and a copy meant to be shown during normal inspections at customs.

All of them were signed with the name of Pope Helena.

There was nothing wrong with the documents—and there could not be anything wrong.

It was just that they had arrived too fast. Vanna had only just returned from the conclave, and the papers were already here.

She held the forms and pass and checked them over and over. After a while, she suddenly heard a voice enter her mind. It was Pope Helena.

“What Captain Duncan wanted has been sent out through an Esoteric Rite.”

Vanna lowered her head and glanced at what she was holding, and her small doubt faded: “Yes, I have received it.”

Then she let out a breath, thanked the Pope, and said goodbye. After that, she put the documents away and hurried out of the cabin.

Duncan was still waiting on the deck. When Vanna, walking quickly, stepped onto the deck, he smiled: “You were gone for quite a while. Did the conclave go well?”

“The conclave went… very well,” Vanna said after a brief pause. What first came to her mind was the three “numberless Visions” from the parchment sheet she had brought out of Vision 004. With a very complicated feeling, she looked at the “person responsible” standing in front of her. Then she handed over the travel papers that had just been sent from the great Storm Cathedral. “But you should look at this first. The pass you wanted.”

“Pass?” Duncan was stunned. He had indeed mentioned the matter to Vanna, but he had not expected her to walk out from a conclave and instantly hand him a pass. The impossible speed left him dazed.

Still, he reached out and took the documents. As he looked them over, he said casually: “Your efficiency is really something… You carry all this stuff on you?”

“Well… it’s a bit complicated,” Vanna said, embarrassed. “I wasn’t the one who signed them. It was Your Eminence Helena. When she heard about…”

She had only said half her sentence when Duncan suddenly cut her off. He snapped his head up: “Wait. Who did you say signed these?”

Vanna froze. She did not know why the captain was reacting so strongly: “It was… Your Eminence Helena. Is something wrong?”

Duncan did not answer. He only stared into Vanna’s eyes for a long time. Then he lowered his head again and stared hard at the handwriting on the travel papers.

His gaze rested on the signature at the bottom of the certificate.

Signer—Gamona.

On the document. On the original certificate. On the copy.

All three signatures were the same.

Chapter 470: Gamona’s “Hint”

The name of the Storm Goddess Gamona appeared on the pass, and Duncan found the handwriting familiar.

He had seen it before. Back in Pland, a being suspected to be the Storm Goddess had left him a message of thanks. He still remembered that God’s handwriting.

Yet Vanna said the pass had been signed by Pope Helena.

Vanna would not make a mistake about something so obvious, and she had no reason to tell such a pointless lie. That left only one explanation – in her eyes, the name on the pass really was Helena.

Who was seeing what was real? What did it mean that the same thing appeared so differently to the two of them? What message was the Storm Goddess trying to send him by doing this? Or rather… what was her purpose?

Duncan controlled his expression and pushed down his shock. He did not feel any obvious wrongness from those few sheets of paper, so he could only try to get more information from Vanna.

He raised his head and looked at the inquisitor opposite him: “What did Helena say when she handed the pass to you?”

“The Pope did not say much, only that what you asked for was ready,” Vanna answered at once, still bothered by Duncan’s strange attitude. Then she carefully recounted everything she and the Pope had discussed about

the pass at the assembly, explaining why the document was signed by Helena. When she finished, she watched Duncan's reaction and finally asked: "These things… is there something wrong with them?"

Duncan was silent for two seconds, then suddenly said: "No. There is no problem. These are very good."

Vanna did not seem to be pretending. She clearly knew nothing. What bothered him more was that, if the details Vanna described were correct, then Pope Helena herself also seemed unaware that the signature on the pass had changed.

Unless the Pope was putting on an act – but why would she do that?

Vanna kept watching Duncan's reaction. She had many doubts, but in the end she did not press him. Instead, she moved on to another important matter:

"Also, this time I again entered that tomb as the Listener. The parchment sheet I brought back has information about new Visions…"

"New Visions?" Duncan raised his eyebrows, a little surprised. "Isn't that something secret to your internal assemblies? Is it really fine to tell me directly?"

"Changes to the Visions list will be made public to the whole world sooner or later. Telling you now only means you know a little earlier. Besides… the new Visions are related to you."

"Oh?"

Vanna steadied herself and said: "Vision-Frostholm, Vision-the Vanished, Vision-the Vanished Fleet. Like the situation with Pland, none of them have a number."

The open deck fell briefly silent. Only the wind brushed past their ears and the waves slapped against the hull. After a long time, Duncan finally spoke, breaking the silence: “Oh. That is quite a lot.”

“Yes, indeed… quite a lot,” Vanna said, a little hesitant. “Under normal circumstances, even a single new Vision is enough to draw the attention of every Church of the Four Gods. This time three Visions were added at once, and one of them is the Vanished that used to be numbered 005…”

“So all the Churches and research organizations will be rather busy next?”

“There will probably be countless scholars losing countless hairs, and the Popes will likely sleep poorly for some time… Even if the new Visions show no obvious danger, the follow-up divination rituals and data work are a huge project.”

Duncan thought for a moment: “Oh. They can work hard on that.”

Even the always calm and steady Vanna almost lost control of her expression at this. A strange feeling spread in her chest. After holding it in for a long time, she finally managed to say: “As the ‘person involved’… you really have no thoughts about it?”

Duncan thought about it seriously, then looked at Vanna with a solemn face: “Next time I will try to make less of a commotion? Or you can go back and persuade your Pope, tell them to take it easy…”

Vanna: “…”

The inquisitor seemed to fall into confusion for a moment. Duncan did not care about her reaction. He lifted his head and looked thoughtfully at the familiar deck and masts before him, and at the translucent spirit form sails billowing in midair.

The Vanished, as always, sailed silently and reliably across the Boundless Sea. As the ship’s master, Duncan did not feel that it had changed in any

way. Yet in the list of Vision 004, the Nameless King's Tomb, this vessel was no longer recorded as Vision 005.

It had lost its number.

What exactly did that change mean?

Duncan lowered his head and looked thoughtfully at his own palm, then his gaze dropped to the pass. The name "Gamona" seemed to carry a strong presence that drew his eyes.

He thought of the brief connection between Dog and the God of Wisdom, and then of that strange dark space and the record he had seen there of what seemed to be a conversation between Gods.

"Vanna," he suddenly turned his head and looked straight into Vanna's eyes. "How can someone establish communication with the Gods?"

Vanna snapped out of her daze at once, then was startled by Duncan's question and looked a little at a loss: "Ah?! You mean… establish communication with the Gods?!"

"That is right," Duncan nodded. "Establish communication with the Gods."

He had just thought of something. If that strange dark space really hid some kind of "communication platform" between the Gods, and if the Blasphemous Tome that had been burned was only a key used to open that dark space, then such a key was likely not only in the hands of a few cults. In other words –

Since even the "blasphemous sacred relics" held by cultists could open that "communication platform" of the Gods, then what about the orthodox churches that were closely linked to the Four Gods? Would the items or techniques in their hands not work even better? It was a very logical thought.

Duncan had not considered this direction before. Part of it was habit of thought. The Golden Sun Mask from before and the Blasphemous Tome this time had both come from cultists, so he had instinctively formed a simple plan of “finding cultists and dealing with them on the spot.” The other part was that he had been avoiding this direction without realizing it.

He had truly seen the role the Churches of the Four Gods played in the city-states, and so he had a natural goodwill toward the power behind Vanna and Morris. Probing that dark space carried risk. The destroyed Golden Sun Mask and Blasphemous Tome proved this. The power of Truth was not something common objects could bear. If handled poorly, at best the sacred relic serving as a medium would be destroyed, and at worst those assisting from the side would risk their lives. It seemed more suitable to let cultists shoulder that kind of danger.

But now, Duncan suddenly had a new idea.

This idea came from the Storm Goddess’s signature on the pass.

It might be a sign of goodwill, or some kind of reminder.

Of course, he could not explain this to Vanna in too much detail. After all, she was still a devout Saint. If he said straight out, “I think cultists’ sacred relics are too hard to find, so I want to try using your Deep Sea Church’s sacred relics instead,” it would obviously be quite improper. She might very well leap at him with an overhead strike…

Vanna did not think about the reason behind Duncan’s casual question. She was only surprised that the captain had suddenly taken an interest in the Gods. But she soon remembered that he did seem to have unique insight and study in theology, so she thought carefully and answered: “That depends on what kind of communication you mean. In general, we call all acts of worship ‘communication with the gods’. Even a simple evening

prayer by an ordinary member of the congregation is a conversation with the god.

“Above that are the ordained priests. Through years of training and practice, and with the help of special rituals and items, they come to understand the god’s ‘knowledge’ and draw power from that knowledge and Truth, or use Listening Rites to receive the god’s revelations. That is a further level of ‘communication’.

“A higher level still is a Saint like me. A Saint does not need very complex ritual preparations. We only need our own spiritual insight to resonate, and we can communicate with the god’s will more directly, because our spiritual insight is connected to the god’s spiritual insight…”

There was a hint of pride in Vanna’s voice at the end, but she noticed Duncan slightly frowning. Clearly, these were not the answers the captain wanted.

“Not that kind of communication,” Duncan shook his head. He slowly searched for the right words, wanting Vanna to understand what he meant. “I mean… something more direct, closer, more efficient… a link, do you understand? Not vaguely receiving a revelation during prayer, but being able to talk directly with the Four Gods.”

Vanna slowly opened her mouth and did not come back to her senses for a long while.

So Duncan knew he probably could not get an answer from her. It was about what he had expected.

“Forget it. This is a bit beyond the mortal realm,” he waved his hand and let out a light breath. “The ritual techniques you use are not useful for me. Maybe it would be more effective if I just found a few Sacred Tomes from the Four Gods’ churches and read them myself.”

Vanna blinked. As usual, she felt she could not quite keep up with the captain’s train of thought.

But thankfully, the captain did not linger on this strange topic.

“Later, go to the White Oak and hand the pass to Lawrence. I will not go over,” Duncan instructed. “If he asks about what comes next, tell him to act with the Vanished for now. When matters here in Frostholm are completely settled, we will plan further.”

Vanna lowered her head: “Yes, Captain.”

Duncan nodded, but then he seemed to hear something. His brows knitted slightly: “Hm?”

Vanna asked curiously: “What is it?”

“Agatha is looking for me,” Duncan said slowly, his expression growing serious. “She says she has found a way to enter the Deep Sea.”

Chapter 471: The Possibilities Behind the key

In Frostholm, in a secret facility deep beneath the southern Harbor, all unrelated personnel had already been cleared from the site. Agatha and Tyrian were waiting together for Duncan to arrive.

Behind them stood the huge machine secretly built by the former City Hall. An egg-shaped pressure-resistant capsule was fixed firmly among the beams by steel cables. Light from the ceiling shone down onto the metal hull of the submersible, making it gleam with a cold, mute sheen.

Silence filled the hall. After a slightly tense wait, Agatha suddenly lifted her head. Her voice, ethereal and hoarse like a Restless Soul, broke the silence: “He is here.”

As soon as she spoke, she spread her hands in midair. Green flames roared up from the scars and cracks all over her body, as if she were embracing a blazing sun. In front of Agatha, a dim green flame suddenly burst upward and gathered into a rotating gate of fire. The skeletal form of Ai was the first to fly out of the gate, followed by a tall figure wrapped in bandages and wearing a black coat.

Tyrian bowed to that figure and stepped half a pace to the side: “Father.”

Agatha lowered her hands and drew back the flames on her body. She clasped her hands before her chest in a prayer-like pose and bowed her head slightly: “I am sorry to trouble you to come in person again.”

“It is fine. This avatar has nothing else to do anyway. Seeing the site in person is more efficient than listening to reports,” Duncan waved his hand and walked past Tyrian and Agatha. His gaze had already fallen on the huge machine behind them. “So… this is it?”

“Yes,” Agatha nodded gently. “This is the legacy left by Governor Winston – and perhaps by other former governors as well. According to our current inspections, the submersible is close to completion and in good condition.”

Duncan gave a quiet “Mm” but did not speak further. He simply stood there in silence, as if gazing upon a fragment of frozen history.

That sealed history seemed to gaze back at him. Time had trapped ambitions and lonely searching that no one could fully know today. Under the crisscrossing lights, in this hall that had almost been buried and forgotten, all the fears and courage of mortals had been cast into this cold steel.

Duncan could almost hear the obsession and the roars cast into the steel.

He took a few steps forward, came to the edge of the railing, and reached out to touch the submersible’s cold, hard shell. Deep within his own body, this shell that had already lost its life, there seemed to be a faint tremor. The feeling disappeared in an instant.

But even that fleeting feeling gave Duncan a sense of familiarity. He searched his memories and found where it came from:

It was when he first set foot on the surface of Pland, standing before Nina as “Uncle Duncan”, and Nina ran toward him with a bright smile, arms wide open. It was when he found that silver brooch on the Vanished and heard someone speak the name “Lucretia”. At those times, faint traces of attachment and memory had surged up from the depths of his heart, like scraps of humanity left in a shell that could never quite be wiped away.

Duncan drew back his arm and lowered his head, looking thoughtfully at his own palm, as if he were gazing at the former master of this body. After a long time, he spoke softly: “Ah. So you know about this…”

Tyrian’s voice came from the side: “Father? What did you say?”

“Nothing,” Duncan turned around. “Can this submersible be used now?”

“Well…” Tyrian sounded a little troubled. “We carefully checked the facility here and the condition of the submersible. The main structure of the submersible is intact, but there are two problems. First, it seems all the original technicians in this facility have been lost, and the documents and equipment left in the outer hall are badly damaged. That problem is still manageable. Some of the ‘old hands’ in the Sea Mist Fleet should be able to handle this thing, since it was built based on the blueprints left by the Queen of Frostholm. The second problem is more troublesome…”

Tyrian paused for a moment, then went on after choosing his words: “From our preliminary checks, we found that this submersible is very different from the ones used back then. It does not rely on air pumps on the surface. Instead, it uses built-in oxygen cylinders. But we have only found where the cylinders should be installed. We have not found any cylinders themselves. Perhaps that part was never finished. That is why Lady Agatha said it is ‘almost complete’. If we want to quickly build an oxygen supply system that fits this submersible now, it may take quite some time.”

Duncan turned his head and looked at Tyrian quietly.

Tyrian grew a little nervous: “Father?”

“I do not need to breathe,” Duncan looked into Tyrian’s eyes. “Is there still a problem now?”

Tyrian: “…”

The new governor of Frostholm froze for a moment, then suddenly realized. An awkward look flashed across his face, and he hurriedly nodded: “Ah. Then there is no problem at all…”

“You can hardly find anyone in the entire Sea Mist Fleet who even needs to breathe, yet you are getting stuck on this,” Duncan shook his head. “It seems everything lately really has worn you out. All right. Since there is no problem, go get ready. I want this submersible made ready in the shortest possible time. That is what I care about most in Frostholm right now.”

Tyrian straightened at once. Though he had not heard an order from his father for a century, his muscles still tensed by reflex: “Yes, Father!”

Then Tyrian left, going to carry out his father’s order as quickly as possible.

Duncan turned around and looked again at the strange diving apparatus for a while. Then he noticed that Agatha was still standing where she had been and looked as if she had something to say.

Duncan turned his head, his gaze sweeping over Agatha and the shadow on the ground beside her. Then he nodded: “You can speak now. It is just us here. Go on, what is happening? Which of you will speak first?”

Agatha was stunned for a moment, then reacted sharply: “You… already noticed?”

“There are two shadows in the firelight. One of them tried very hard to hide, but the flames on your bodies come from me. From my point of view, that kind of hiding is… clumsy,” Duncan turned back, his eyes a little gentle. “I noticed as soon as I arrived, but since you did not want to mention it just now, I did not ask.”

“I only thought this matter should not be made known to General Tyrian for the moment.”

As Agatha spoke, she slowly stepped aside.

Her shadow stayed where it was.

The next second, the shadow left on the ground suddenly rippled. A vague, ghostly figure rose from it, wearing what seemed to be the old attire of a Gatekeeper. The figure bent slightly toward Duncan, and a hoarse voice almost identical to Agatha's sounded: "It is good to see you, Duncan… Captain."

"This should be my first time seeing you," Duncan looked at the wavering shadow with a hint of surprise. After studying it curiously for a few seconds, he suddenly raised his head to look at Agatha not far away. "Is she always this blurry?"

"She is very clear when she is in a mirror, but there is no mirror here," Agatha explained at once. "Also, from our tests, she becomes blurry when she feels nervous. The more nervous she is, the blurrier she gets. Right now… she is a little nervous in front of you."

"How remarkable," Duncan found it more and more incredible. He looked at the phantom. Even though he had already sensed her presence earlier, he still could not help his amazement now. "I thought you had already scattered into the darkness. Agatha read the memories you left behind when you faded."

"I did fade for a time, but in the end I returned to this world," the hazy shadow said. "I am sorry. I do not know how to explain the process either. When I became aware of my own existence again, I was already a reflection in a mirror…"

Agatha spoke again: "We suspect it has to do with that 'key', but we have no proof."

"The key?"

“The brass key,” Agatha nodded. “From her hazy impression, she reappeared in this world when I took hold of that brass key. Perhaps that key does more than store information. It might also preserve memories, personality, or even a soul to some extent. When the right conditions are met, the stored memories and soul can be ‘reshaped’ in some form…”

Duncan listened quietly and did not speak right away.

The key left behind by Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm was now aboard the Vanished, in the hand of his true body. Out of caution, he had not yet tried using that key on Alice, and now it seemed… that caution might have been right!

Agatha touched the key, and the “replica Agatha” who had once also held the key had returned to this world. So if he used the key on Alice, what would happen?

Could that key be storing Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm’s memories, or even her soul?

For generations, every governor of Frostholm had been affected over and over whenever they came into contact with the brass key. They had been forced to learn the truth of the Abyssal Trench Project, forced to inherit the Queen of Frostholm’s “legacy”, and even had their own wills disturbed by the Queen’s will. All this influence had always been crudely explained as “the Queen of Frostholm’s curse”. But what had happened to Agatha now made Duncan aware of the possibilities behind that key.

When he thought again of how Alice had the exact same face as the Queen of Frostholm, those possibilities pointed toward an even more unsettling direction: the doll was the vessel, and the key held the soul. Put together, they would be the Queen of Frostholm.

Duncan kept silent, though he sighed softly in his heart.

He understood now why Agatha had not brought this up in front of Tyrian earlier.

But then he suddenly felt that something about this was not right.

Alice as a doll, and the brass key that could “store a soul”… were those really enough to bring about the Queen of Frostholm’s return? Could things truly be that simple?

Chapter 472: Doubts about The key

Out on the distant Boundless Sea, Duncan sat at the desk in the captain’s cabin and frowned slightly.

He reached out and opened the hidden compartment beneath the desk. From the concealed space, he felt out the brass key that Agatha had discovered earlier and handed to him, and set it in front of himself to examine it closely.

The winding key had an old-fashioned design and a cold metallic sheen. It reflected the sunlight pouring in from the window. Tiny decorative patterns caught his eye on the handle, which was shaped like an infinity symbol.

This was not the first time Duncan had studied the key, but this time, as he used his gaze on this “Queen’s relic”, his feelings were completely different from before.

This might be Ray Nora’s “soul vessel”. That possibility made his gaze grow complicated.

Ray Nora, the Queen of Frostholm, was a great person. The secrets hidden in her drew Duncan’s attention even more. If there was a chance for him to establish communication with Ray Nora, that would of course be a good thing—but the premise could not be gambling with Alice.

In the city of Frostholm, Duncan, wearing a black coat, narrowed his eyes slightly. He seemed to rein in the thoughts that had scattered for a moment.

His gaze fell again on Agatha, and on the hazy shadowy “Agatha” beside her.

He suddenly asked: “Do you still remember your experiences moving through the city-state as a ‘replica’?”

“Yes, I remember everything,” the shadowy figure seemed to nod as she spoke. “I also remember going deep into the mine and melding into that strange region of After the Darkness…”

Duncan said: “I already know that part. Agatha… I mean, the ‘original’ Agatha, has already reported this to me.” A thoughtful look came over his face. “To be honest, your appearance reminds me of someone.”

“Someone?” the two Agathas said almost in unison.

“A soul shadow named Martha,” Duncan said slowly. “She is Lawrence’s wife and a new member of my fleet. For the last ten-odd years, her identity has been that of a ‘replica’ wandering in mirror world Frostholm.”

The hazy phantom Agatha shifted slightly.

“In the past ten-odd years, that ‘replica’ wandered in the space of the mirror world,” Duncan went on, his gaze resting on the blurry figure. “She drew in and gathered a huge number of fragments of thoughts and memories. That made her grow into a vast ‘composite’, and ‘Martha’ is the core personality of that composite.

“From how things look now, your situation is very similar to Martha’s. The difference is that you have not yet become a composite like hers. You are still in an early, pure stage. Of course, since mirror world Frostholm has been destroyed, you will probably stay in this stage from now on.”

“It turns out there is… something like this,” said the genuine Agatha. Her tone carried disbelief. “I thought what happened to me was an exception…”

“It is not an exception. That is why it interests me even more,” Duncan said calmly, though his gaze still rested on the hazy figure. “When mirror world Frostholm faded, all the ‘replicas’ vanished with it. But now two ‘personalities’ remain.

“Does that mean the power that supports replica Martha and replica Agatha is not that mirror world city itself, but something else? The personalities and memories copied from that sea region can keep existing stably in the Mortal Realm, and Martha is even now outside the Frostholm sea. Does that at the same time mean… the power that maintains replica Agatha and replica Martha is something as vast and stable as the Mortal Realm itself?”

Silence fell over the hall where the submersible was parked.

After who knew how long, Agatha finally lifted her head and quietly met her own “shadow’s” gaze.

Duncan suddenly broke the silence: “Have you two thought about the future?”

“The future?” Agatha was stunned, as if she had never thought along that line. “You mean…”

“A person cannot live forever as someone else’s shadow—literally a shadow,” Duncan said, his gaze resting on the hazy phantom. “You should think about the days ahead.”

The blurry phantom fell silent. After a long time, she spoke with a hint of hesitation: “But I really am her shadow.”

“I will say it again: a ‘person’ cannot live forever as another person’s shadow,” Duncan still said calmly as he looked at her with his gaze. “You have your own personality and your own memories. Maybe more than twenty of those years belong to someone else, but at least the last few days belong to you.

“So what about from now on, Agatha?”

When Duncan spoke the name “Agatha”, both figures looked up at the same time without thinking.

His gaze swept over the two of them. Then he let out a light breath and said: “Think it over. It’s all right. We still have plenty of time.”

…

A knock on the door outside the captain’s cabin broke Duncan’s train of thought.

He drew most of his attention back from his “avatar form” in the Frostholm city-state, lifted his head, and looked toward the door of his bedroom: “Come in.”

The door opened. Alice poked her head in first to take a look, then slipped into the room like a thief, holding a plate of still-steaming pastries in her hands: “I learned how to bake cookies!”

With a proud tone, she set the pastries on the table in front of Duncan, then glanced around the room as if looking for Ai.

“Ai is in Frostholm,” Duncan said casually, his eyes resting on the Brother Doll in front of him.

This was the “inner room” of the captain’s cabin, his bedroom. On the whole ship, besides Nina, only Alice could walk into this room so casually.

She was the first person—the first humanoid being—he had met after coming to this world.

He trusted her. Although she was not very reliable, Duncan knew that this doll young lady’s honesty and trust in him outweighed everything. Even though this almost extreme trust mostly came from her simple, solid brain,

in this cold and unfamiliar world, that first and deepest trust still felt very precious.

Alice finally noticed Duncan's gaze. She turned her head in confusion, checked her clothes, then touched her neck and asked: "Why are you staring at me?"

"It's nothing," Duncan withdrew his gaze and casually picked up a cookie from the plate, popping it into his mouth. "…It tastes okay."

Alice laughed happily.

Then she noticed the brass key lying on the table.

"Ah, you're studying this key," Alice said. She picked it up without thinking and played with it curiously. Then she felt around her back. "Are you going to wind me up?"

"Don't mess with it." Duncan reached out and snatched the key back, his tone turning very serious. "From now on, you cannot touch this key without my permission."

Maybe she had not seen Duncan this serious for a long time. Alice was even a little frightened. She quickly pulled her hands back. A tense, almost scared look came over her face: "S-sorry…"

"Sorry, I scared you," Duncan said at once, realizing it and softening his tone. "You did nothing wrong, and I'm not scolding you—it's just that this key may be dangerous for you."

"Dangerous?" Alice blinked, as if she could not understand. She reached back in confusion and felt the keyhole through her clothes. "But I heard Shirley and Nina say… this key should be used to wind me up… Ah, Nina even bought a wind-up toy soldier in the city. I played with it for a long time. The toy soldier's winding key was just like this…"

Duncan rubbed his brow. Even though he knew Alice might find it hard to understand, he still explained patiently: “This key is not something that simple. It is an extraordinary item, do you understand? Queen Ray Nora left it behind, and I now suspect this is some kind of method she prepared to revive herself.”

Alice stared straight into Duncan’s eyes. After a long while, she drew out her voice: “Ah… ah?”

“Ray Nora’s memories and soul might be stored in this key,” Duncan said. He was not surprised by Alice’s reaction. He only sighed softly, pressed the key down on the table, and looked at the doll in front of him. “And you look exactly the same as Ray Nora.”

After staring blankly for a while, Alice finally began to understand. She lowered her head to look at her own body, then looked at the key pinned to the table by the captain. After a long time she asked: “So, if you wind me up, that Frostholm Queen might be able to control my body?”

“That is what I’m worried about,” Duncan nodded. In front of this simple-minded doll, he did not hide his thoughts. “Of course, this worry is not very… reasonable. There are still many doubtful points.”

“Doubtful points?”

“The biggest one is how uncontrollable the whole process is,” Duncan said. “You should know how you were found. Your doll’s spirit coffin drifted in the sea near Frostholm and was salvaged by a passing ship by chance.

“And the key? The key was in the hands of the city-state’s successive governors. They passed it down for half a century, yet no one knew about the link between the key and you, this doll. If this is the Frostholm Queen’s method of reviving herself, then it depends far too much on luck.

“The doll might not end up together with the key. The person who gets the key might not know of its connection to the doll. Even if they know, they might not choose to turn the key. Even Tyrian does not know any of this. Who would wind you up then? And besides… under the terrifying label of Anomaly 099, how many people would even dare approach the doll’s spirit coffin?”

Alice half understood as she listened to the captain. After she finally grasped most of it, she asked curiously: “Then… what about the other doubtful points?”

“The other doubts…”

Duncan thought for a moment. In his mind, he suddenly recalled the Frostholm Queen he had seen in the “vision” when he had probed Alice’s “coffin” earlier, and the sentence the Frostholm Queen had left—

Please do not corrupt history.

Would the Frostholm Queen, who had calmly gone to her death in the face of fate, really arrange a backup plan to revive herself decades later?

Chapter 473: The Blasphemous Archetype and the Fall

Alice left.

Duncan did not know how much this silly doll had actually understood, but at least she now realized that the key was dangerous. Before they figured out its true nature, she probably would not think about winding herself up again.

Outside the window, the evening sun was slowly sinking. The two brilliant rune rings were drawing closer and closer to the distant horizon. Their spreading red-gold light dyed the whole sea, then passed through the window and spilled into the room.

Duncan sat at the desk by the window, quietly turning his gaze on the brass key. sunlight covered the handle, which was shaped like an infinity symbol. The fine patterns on it seemed to come to life in the light, flowing as the shadows shifted.

After a short moment of thought and hesitation, Duncan took a quiet breath and reached out to grip the key.

A trace of fine, ghostly green flame appeared at his fingertips and slowly seeped into the key.

He had not planned to use the fire of spirit form to study the key, because the Power of Flame could very easily damage the key’s extraordinary

nature. Even if it did not destroy it, it might change what it was. But now he could no longer worry about that.

He had to find out what Ray Nora had left inside the key. Under that premise, he could only be extremely careful. He tried his best to keep the fire of spirit form from burning the thing too fiercely, while he felt for every tiny bit of information that the flames brought back. He was ready to snuff them out at once if anything felt wrong.

The flame flowed like water between his fingers and the key. The ghostly green light seeped bit by bit into the brass surface. In Duncan's senses, his fire seemed to be sinking into a vast and boundless place full of strange chaos.

He slowly closed his eyes and used the spreading flames as his eyes, beginning to observe the "world" behind the key.

Mist. Endless mist. It flowed like dust and smoke, rising and sinking in his field of view, sometimes condensing, sometimes scattering. Everywhere the flame could see, there was only chaotic emptiness.

Duncan watched the dense mist in confusion, but in every direction he saw only the same, even chaos.

He knew this was the "reality" inside the key. He was doing the same thing he had done when he probed the doll's spirit coffin back then. However, what he found here was completely different from the inside of that spirit coffin.

He stayed still in the endless fog for a while. He could sense the flames still spreading steadily, and the key itself showed no sign of being harmed or damaged. Only then did he breathe a little easier and tentatively try to move his view in one direction.

But as soon as he moved forward, he felt the texture of something foreign in his palm.

“The key?”

Duncan first thought of the brass key he held in the Mortal Realm. Then he realized something else—he actually had a “body” in this thick mist.

He clearly remembered that last time, when he had examined the doll’s spirit coffin, he had only had a “field of view”.

Why had this changed? Was it because the two extraordinary items had different natures, or because his own power had gone through some unknown change?

Questions rose sharply in Duncan’s heart. At the same time he lifted his hand without thinking and looked at the “foreign object” in his palm.

A rectangular object with a black shell lay quietly there. From the feel, he could not tell if it was metal or plastic.

Duncan froze.

It was only about half a palm in length and two fingers wide. Its smooth, flat surface was clearly the product of some kind of crafting. Under the black shell he could vaguely see fine lines that might have been decorative or part of the internal structure. At one end he saw a complex metallic port, with a row of evenly spaced raised contacts inside.

It looked as if it was some kind of “readable device” that could be plugged into a machine to store data or act as a starter.

Duncan held the black rectangle up before his eyes, studying every detail of it with a feeling of nameless shock.

He thought of USB drives from “the other world”, or portable hard drives, but the specifications of this device’s port were clearly unlike any he knew.

After he stared at it for a long time, another thing suddenly came to mind—

In Pland, in the History Branch that had been consumed by a great fire, he had seen the Sunspawn who invaded the city-state all holding a black parasol. Inside that black parasol he had glimpsed complex, advanced, and precise mechanical, even electronic, structures…

Duncan remembered the black parasol he had seen in Pland, and then examined the rectangular device in his hand again. In the end he confirmed that the Sunspawn's black parasol and this strange "device" did not seem to have the same style. They looked like products of two different technological routes or design styles, yet they shared something in common —

Precision, advancement, complexity. Just from their appearance, they seemed far beyond the level of technology in this world.

At the very least, they did not look like anything the city-states of the Boundless Sea could make, or had ever made.

And in this world, things like this seemed to have a special name:

Blasphemous Archetype.

Dog had once described them like this:

"In the long river of this world's years, some parts of history are 'locked'. The things that were born in those forbidden histories are Blasphemous Archetypes. In most cases, their very existence is harmful to living beings in the Mortal Realm…"

This "black box" that looked like some kind of data device… was it a Blasphemous Archetype?

Duncan frowned slightly, turning the little device over and over in his hand while he thought about what connection it had with the brass key he was

holding in the Mortal Realm. Just then, a strange, low rumbling sound suddenly came from somewhere extremely high and far away, cutting off his thoughts.

Duncan lifted his head in shock and looked toward the source of the sound.

The next second, he saw a sudden bright light appear in the endless chaotic mist that filled the space. The light came from far away like a meteor falling hard, then formed a blazing fireball in the fog.

It roared over Duncan's head, lowering in altitude as it flew. The mist was blown aside. Within the dazzling ball of fire, some huge thing took shape. Duncan saw a solid object driven by flame—

It looked like three spindle-shaped bodies bound together. At the end of each spindle he could see a huge stream of light bursting from some kind of thruster. Thick smoke billowed along the outer hulls. Fire flared everywhere, and shocking explosions and tears kept ripping through them. Chunks of debris kept breaking off from the blast points and fell like rain into the thick mist, turning into shooting stars as they fell and burned out in the sky…

With no point of reference, Duncan could not judge how big the "three-bodied ship" streaking across the sky really was. But he could feel the overpowering shock and pressure of that huge form wrapped in flame and smoke. It might have been bigger than a city-state, even bigger than many city-states put together. It might have crossed a long journey, gliding past the stars on some astronomical scale.

Now it slid and fell through this vision wrapped in mist, and in Duncan's stunned gaze, the fall ended in a world-shaking explosion—

With an explosion that seemed enough to shake all of space and time, the "ark-ship" made of three spindles broke apart.

It split into three pieces that became three burning fireballs. Three blinding trails laden with thick smoke scattered into the depths of the fog.

They were very far away, at a distance one could never reach on foot.

Moreover, Duncan doubted that even if he could teleport thousands of miles, he still would not be able to reach the place where those three pieces of wreckage had fallen.

Because this fog only recorded something that had happened in the distant past.

A faint warmth came from his palm. Duncan lowered his head and saw a brass key lying quietly in his hand. The handle at the end of the brass key, shaped like an infinity symbol, was giving off a soft glow. The fine lines on it slowly moved in the light and formed symbols he could recognize:

“The New Hope”

“Boom!”

A phantom roar suddenly exploded in his mind. The fog around him vanished into darkness. Then light and shadow shifted, and the familiar scene of his bedroom returned to his sight.

Duncan steadied himself and felt his senses quickly return. He lowered his head again and saw the brass key still lying quietly in his hand.

The key was no longer warm or glowing. The fine lines on its handle no longer flowed. The characters that had floated before his eyes just now felt like bubbles that had vanished with the end of a dream.

But Duncan still clearly remembered everything he had seen. He remembered that name—

The New Hope.

He frowned, quickly stood up, and took the notebook from the desk. He wrote down the words “The New Hope”, then hurriedly jotted a rough record of the scene he had seen in the “vision”. Only after he had written everything down did he breathe a little easier and sit back the way he had at the start.

In this world, it was unlikely that anything could affect his memory and thoughts, but he still had to keep the necessary caution.

After finishing the record, Duncan fell into deep thought.

He did not know the causes and consequences of what he had seen. He did not know what kind of link or “transformation” process existed between the black data device in the vision and the brass key. He did not know where the fallen ark-ship was now. But he believed that everything he had seen was not some confused hallucination.

It was something that had really happened once. It was real history that had taken place in this world in the distant past, in years before even the Age of City-States had begun.

A huge ship had crashed into this world. It exploded as it fell, and its wreckage scattered across the mortal world.

Duncan let out a soft breath.

He put the key away close to his body, raised his head, and looked out the window at Vision 001, which had almost completely sunk down to the sea’s surface.

“This time… things just got a lot more interesting.”

Chapter 474: Morris’s Knowledge Blind Spot

When the veil of night descended, Morris was called to the captain’s cabin.

Duncan sat behind the enchanted sea chart table with a serious face. On the tabletop beside his hand, a messy pile of books had already formed. Some were books they had brought from Pland and Frostholm, and some had been acquired from the Sea Mist Fleet.

After they confirmed that reading at sea was harmless, the number of books on the ship kept growing.

Morris glanced at the table and saw that the books covered all kinds of topics. There were strange tales from various city-states, authoritative works on history, and some dangerous reading that dealt with Doomsday theories and Records of revelation and other fringe doctrines.

The old scholar felt curiosity stir in his heart, along with a thin thread of unease.

The captain seemed to have suddenly decided to look for some specific information. Judging from the books he had taken out, what he wanted to find was probably not simple at all. If he had called Morris here, it was most likely to ask about such things.

Becoming a little more cautious, Morris quickly recited the name of the God of Wisdom Rahm in his mind, praying in silent Prayer for a blessing over his thoughts. He also lowered his head to check the charm amulet on

his wrist, a string of colored stones, before sitting down opposite the captain and asking: “What did you call me here for?”

“…I ran into some problems and need to ask a learned man like you for advice,” Duncan nodded. Then he seemed to notice the tension on Morris’s face. He smiled and tried to reassure him as he added, “Don’t be so nervous. I just want to ask a few things. It might have something to do with history.”

Just a few questions? History? Secrets of Truth so obscure that even the Master of the Vanished could not be sure of them?

Hearing the captain’s comforting words, Morris hurriedly flipped Rahm’s name back and forth in his heart a dozen more times, piling that foolish divine blessing on layer after layer. Only then did he tense his nerves and raise his head: “I am ready. Please ask.”

Duncan: “…”

Feeling a bit helpless, Duncan knew this reaction from the old mister was only natural. He sighed, then began to speak while choosing his words: “In the history you know, has there ever been a description of something like this – some gigantic man-made object falling from the sky, accompanied by great flames and flashes of light? This fallen relic might also have exploded, breaking into several smaller pieces that then fell onto the world.”

When he finished, Duncan looked straight into Morris’s eyes.

Morris stared back, stunned.

“…Is that all?” the old scholar asked hesitantly.

“That’s it, that’s all,” Duncan nodded. Of course he had many more details, but for such a vague question about history, too many details might actually affect Morris’s judgment. So he chose the simplest way to put it. “If history

recorded something like this, the words might be different, but the main event should still be built around the scene of a huge object falling in flames. Do you know of any similar event?”

The question the captain had suddenly thrown out was puzzling, but Morris noticed how serious Duncan was and still tried hard to recall and think. After several minutes, he slowly shook his head: “I have never seen a record like that.”

“In all official histories and unofficial histories?” Duncan was not surprised by Morris’s answer, but he still asked, unwilling to give up. “This event may have been turned into myth, or even become part of some Heretic doctrines, because it might have happened in a very distant past.”

“I am very sure,” Morris answered again. “In all official histories, unofficial histories, and Heretic doctrines I have ever come across, there is no record that matches or even resembles the scene you described. Of course, that does not rule out the chance that this event is written down in some obscure legend that spread only in a tiny circle, or some part of history that has already been lost. There is always something unknown beyond what we know, but…”

Morris paused for a moment, then continued: “If it is a hidden piece of history so secret that even I do not know it, then it will be very hard for you to find any material about it from other sources. Maybe you can try your luck at the Truth Academy’s grand library, and look for clues in the oldest books in Morka and Lightwind Harbor.”

For a while Duncan did not speak. His calm gaze sank into thought. After a long time, he gave a slight nod: “You can write to the scholars you know and ask about this. If we really need to contact the headquarters of the Truth Academy, that is also fine.”

Hearing the captain’s serious tone, Morris straightened at once and nodded solemnly.

It seemed this matter was truly very important.

As an old scholar who had studied knowledge all his life, he could not help feeling his own curiosity stir. He could not hold back from asking: “May I ask something? The thing you spoke of… what exactly is it?”

Duncan hesitated for a moment, then slowly answered: “I am not sure. I touched on certain visions by chance. But even if I cannot be sure what it really is… I feel that scene is probably closely tied to why our world looks the way it does today, and to much of the history that has been lost.”

“I understand,” Morris bowed his head deeply. “I will find a way to investigate.”

He did not keep asking for details, and he did not ask what kind of “visions” the captain had mentioned, because he knew that curiosity and the desire to explore must be just right, not too little and not too much.

After a short pause, Duncan added: “‘The New Hope’. When you search through the material, pay special attention to these words.”

“That sounds like the name of a ship?” Morris asked, thinking it over.

Duncan thought for a moment, then nodded with a strange expression: “Yes… a ship.”

It was indeed a ship. A spaceship whose engine exploded, which fell from the starry sea down to the earth.

…

In Frostholm’s south port, inside a hidden underground facility, Undying engineers were hard at work.

Knowledge from half a century ago was once again useful. Ancient Blueprints had been taken out from the fleet's stores. Engineers as old as those Blueprints gathered with excitement among heaps of machines, pipes, and cables, talking about knowledge and ideas that to ordinary people would sound like some secret script from heaven.

Tyrian sat in a corner of the hall, watching his subordinates rushing around.

"I really did not think that, in my lifetime, I would see these Blueprints put to use again," an Undying engineer said excitedly beside him. His head was shriveled, his chest had a hole in it, and half his body was driven by a steam engine. He held the drawings in his hands as he spoke. "Look at these drainage devices and balance mechanisms. They made many modern changes to the Submersible, but the basic principles are still the same as back then. Flood the tanks, sink, pump the water out, float back up, and use ballast weights in the bilge to help…"

"I understand why you are excited," Tyrian glanced at his subordinate. "But I must remind you of one thing. You are no longer in your lifetime."

"Close enough. My 'time-until-death' works too," the shriveled-headed Undying engineer laughed, his broken teeth making his grin look quite scary. He raised his hand and gave the steam engine that made up half his body a heavy knock. The gears, which had been running a bit roughly, clacked a few times and started turning smoothly again. Then he looked up at the Submersible in the distance, surrounded by his comrades. After a long silence, he spoke with a bit of feeling: "Ah… if only we could meet its builders. It was designed very well. They really put their hearts into it… They must have truly wanted this thing to be used."

Tyrian said nothing. He only watched the Submersible in the middle of the hall with quiet gaze. After a long time, he sighed softly: "Go and get back to work. This time it really will be used. Do not let anything go wrong."

“Yes, Captain.”

His subordinate left. Tyrian let out a slow breath. At that moment, a faint humming suddenly came from the scrying crystal lens by his hand. Right after that came Lucretia’s teasing voice: “You look worried, Brother. It seems being Governor is not very easy?”

Tyrian turned his face toward the sound without changing his expression and looked at the scrying crystal on the table as it slowly lit up. Lucretia’s image appeared in the crystal sphere.

“I went to all the trouble of moving this thing here from the ship, not so I could listen to you make jokes about your Big Brother,” he said.

“Relax a little, Brother. You are not a Pirate Lord anymore. A Governor has to be both dignified and approachable,” Lucretia smiled, as if she did not care at all about the displeasure in Tyrian’s tone. Then her voice shifted as she asked curiously, “But I really do want to know. Was this… truly Father’s arrangement?”

“What else?” Tyrian sighed. “He did something big here. Something you cannot even imagine. Now the whole of Frostholm is under his influence. I should feel lucky that he really has regained his humanity, so even though this arrangement is surprising, it is at least not bad. Frostholm and my Sea Mist Fleet both have an answer now.”

Lucretia finally put away her faintly teasing smile. After thinking for a moment, she hesitated and asked: “How is Father… now?”

“He is doing very well. His true body is on the Vanished. He spends his days either fishing or feeding pigeons. His avatar form is in Frostholm. Every morning he goes for a walk in the park, and every afternoon he comes here to supervise the progress of the project. You care that much?

Next time he comes, I can switch on the scrying crystal and let you talk to him directly?”

“Ah, better not!” Lucretia almost raised her voice by reflex, then hurried to return to the posture of a lady. “I… I still need to prepare myself. Let’s not talk about that. I still have a lot of things to handle over here…”

“Things over there?” Tyrian raised his eyebrows without thinking. “Speaking of that, how is your research going? What is the situation now with that ‘fragment’ that fell from the sky?”

Lucretia hesitated. She had only picked a random excuse to change the subject, but now she could not help letting out a sigh.

“There is no progress. Even Taran Ael in Lightwind Harbor has no way forward.”

Chapter 475: Taking the First Step in Exploration

Taran Ael was an outstanding elf scholar, an expert in mathematics, machinery, and general studies, and a recipient of four Lifetime Honors granted by the Truth Academy.

He was a man devoted to learning, a careful and diligent worker, someone who could stay in the lab without sleep or rest, and someone who made Lucretia worry all the time that he might suddenly drop dead at his research site.

Now, this well-read Grand Scholar openly announced in front of everyone that he had no way to deal with the geometric glowing orb that had fallen from the sky.

Lucretia raised her head. Her gaze went past the scrying crystal in front of her and landed on the window across from her. From that direction, a magnificent glow was spreading. Even though it was already midnight, the whole sea still seemed to be bathed in “sunlight”. In the middle of that glow, the huge luminous geometric body that was like a small mountain floated quietly on the sea. Its smooth, glowing walls were like steep cliffs, blocking the horizon between sky and sea.

Another small boat crossed the shining waters, heading toward the inside of that luminous geometric body. It was going to pick up the research team that had finished its shift near the “stone sphere”.

Lucretia sighed, pulling back her gaze from the window and looking down at the table by her hand. A strange, grayish ball sat on the stand on the tabletop.

Its surface was rough, with the texture of rock. Odd, uneven ridges with no clear pattern covered it. It looked plain, yet it gave off a mysterious feeling that was hard to put into words.

At the center of the huge geometric glowing orb floating on the sea, there was a bizarre stone sphere ten meters in diameter. The ball in front of Lucretia… was a small but precise replica of that stone sphere.

It was almost the only "result" that a large group of expert scholars had managed to produce after all this time.

"Taran Ael has gone back to Lightwind Harbor to rest. To be exact, his students 'dragged' him back to Lightwind Harbor," Lucretia shook her head and said to her Big Brother on the other side of the scrying crystal. "If he did not rest, I was afraid he might just drop dead outside. For an elf, dying suddenly at five hundred years old would be far too early."

"When he left, he was very discouraged, because this 'object from heaven' is completely beyond our understanding. Whether it is the glowing area around it or the nature of the core sphere itself, it is all a mystery to us.

"The researchers scraped some samples from the stone sphere, but analysis showed that they were just very fine stone dust. Probing the inside of the stone sphere had no progress at all. Every method failed, even extraordinary power. It is as if the thing is wrapped in a dense shell that hides all its secrets. At least for now, we have not yet made up our minds to carry out any destructive… 'tests' on it.

"After all this effort, we only reached one agreement, and that is… this huge geometric glowing orb really does seem to have fallen from the rune

rings around Vision 001. This is the conclusion given by the ‘tower’ in Lightwind Harbor. They carefully examined the gap at the edge of Vision 001 and found that the missing part matches the ‘geometric glowing orb’.”

Lucretia spoke in one breath. Clearly, she had been holding in a lot of frustration these days. Tyrian proved to be a good listener. He did not interrupt once while his Younger Sister talked. Only after she finished did he slowly say: “So it has been confirmed that it is a part that broke off from Vision 001… Lucy, before this, Father already warned the Church of the Four Gods about this. He said the Sun may be heading toward decline.”

“I heard about that,” Lucretia nodded lightly. “A warning from ‘Captain Duncan’. No one dared treat it lightly, even if most people’s first reaction after hearing it was to feel tense and afraid of the Vanished…”

Tyrian pulled at the corner of his mouth. As someone who had been seeing “Duncan Abnomar” often lately, and who had seen Father’s new means with his own eyes, he really did not know what to say. He could only change the topic: “So do you have any follow-up plans? For the problem of the Sun…”

“What plans could we have? Throw this big stone ball back into the sky? Set it back into the Sun’s rune rings?” Lucretia shrugged. “I am afraid only the ancient kingdom of Critt would know how to repair the Sun in the sky.”

Tyrian fell silent.

After a moment of silence, Lucretia suddenly asked: “Does Father know about my ‘research’ here?”

“I have not told him,” Tyrian shook his head. “Without your permission, I would not say a word. Why? Do you want to ask him for help?”

Lucretia clearly hesitated, as if she really was tempted. But soon she shook her head: “I will think about it. He might not be able to help with something

like this anyway, and… fine, I admit it, I am a little afraid of him."

"He is actually quite easy to talk to now," Tyrian laughed. "But since you do not want that, I will not interfere. Still, let me say this first. Even if I do not tell him, the news might reach his ears someday. He is in contact with the Church and the city-states now. If he becomes interested at some point, I will not dare stand in his way."

Lucretia waved her hand in annoyance. In front of her family, this "Sea Witch" who seemed shrouded in mystery to outsiders rarely bothered to hide her emotions: "I know, I know. Let's drop it. When are you going to give me that Spirit Realm lens you promised?"

Tyrian: "…"

Two seconds later, Lucretia's sharp, unhappy shout rang from the scrying crystal: "You forgot again?!?!"

…

"Tyrian, you don't look very well."

Early in the morning, Duncan came to the south port. Seeing the faint tiredness on Tyrian's face, he could not help saying that.

Tyrian rubbed his forehead and sighed helplessly: "There has just been too much to worry about lately."

This was not an excuse. There really was a lot to worry about these days. Managing a city-state clearly took far more effort than leading a fleet. But to be honest… being nagged at high intensity by his Younger Sister for two hours straight also had a real impact on his "complexion".

Soon, Tyrian went around this slightly awkward topic. He did not mention Lucretia. Instead he straightened his expression: "The reason I called you here so early is to tell you that the Submersible is ready."

Duncan raised his eyebrows: “So soon?”

“Once we considered that the passengers do not need to breathe, many of the preparations could be sped up,” Tyrian nodded. “And this secret Submersible built by the former Frostholm government was constructed based on Blueprints from the Queen’s era. Although there are many improvements, the basic principles have not changed much. If we only want to understand how to operate it, that is actually quite simple.”

Duncan looked at Tyrian for a moment, then withdrew his gaze and nodded with satisfaction: “Good. Take me to it.”

“You want to start right away?” Tyrian was a little surprised. “We can run a few more tests. I asked you here today only so you could see it with your own eyes…”

Duncan cut him off: “You have already done some tests, haven’t you?”

“…A little,” Tyrian hesitated. “After we finished the system checks, I sent two Undying sailors on a short dive last night, only a few dozen meters. It was mainly to confirm the operating procedures and working state of the Submersible. Nothing went wrong…”

“That is enough,” Duncan nodded and turned toward the warehouse that led down into the underground facility. “I will personally complete the rest of the testing. In any case, I am the one who has to carry out the actual Deep Dive mission.”

Tyrian froze for a moment, then quickly followed after Duncan. On the hurried way to the facility, he could not help feeling a hint of doubt.

He did not know if it was just his imagination, but he felt that today Father seemed a bit weighed down, and this sense of urgency was not normal for him.

It was as if Duncan had suddenly noticed some clue or touched upon some great secret, and now the urge to uncover the riddle and seek the truth was pushing him forward.

And this hurried manner… gave Tyrian a faint sense of familiarity.

The tall figure in the black coat walked quickly in front, and Tyrian hurried to keep up from behind.

As he watched Duncan's back and followed step by step, Tyrian suddenly realized where this familiar feeling came from.

It felt just like many years ago.

Whenever they found clues to some ancient ruins, whenever a new route appeared on the enchanted sea chart, whenever news came from the borderlands about mysterious Visions, Father would be like this.

This was how he looked right before he set off on a voyage.

Long-faded memories rose uncontrollably from the depths of Tyrian's mind. The scenes of sailing with Father in the past appeared before his eyes. In those overlapping images, Tyrian's steps slowed without him noticing.

Duncan stopped and turned, looking at him with some confusion.

"Tyrian, what are you daydreaming about? Hurry up and keep up."

Tyrian jolted, then quickly stepped forward and answered in a rush: "Ah… oh, yes, Father!"

Duncan turned back and kept walking, not paying much attention to Tyrian's reaction.

Because that urgent desire to explore the world had risen in him once more, pushing at him again and again.

It came from what he had gained yesterday while probing that brass key. It came from that sudden glimpse beneath a corner of this world's mysterious veil.

A vast ship that had crashed on this world in some lost age, a creation of an ancient civilization from hidden history called the "Blasphemous Archetype", secrets in the deep layers that even a Grand Scholar like Morris had never touched.

There were too many unknown things. A clue appearing by chance only made him more aware of how tangled and layered the world's secrets were, like veil upon veil.

So every chance to take a step toward the truth of the world became extremely precious.

An Explorer should be this way.

Chapter 476: Descent

Beneath South Port, the submersible control hall was brightly lit.

Light from gas lamps and electric bulbs poured down, making the entire hall as bright as day. A huge egg-shaped diving apparatus hung from steel cables at the top of the rail that led out to the sea. Undying engineers hurried everywhere, busy with the final checks and adjustments before the submersible entered the water.

At the steel-frame platform that held the submersible in place, Duncan sat on a chair, calmly watching all of this, waiting for Tyrian's subordinates to finish their preparations.

Those Undying, whose faces were strange and ugly, even almost frightening, seemed very excited, with a faint joy and thrill about them.

A burly bald man with a nervous, uneasy look on his face walked over from not far away. He bent down awkwardly in front of Duncan and said: "Uh… old captain, it's good to see you…"

Duncan looked up at the burly man in a seafarer shirt, his scalp shining, his skin as pale as a corpse. He compared him with the information he had learned before and nodded lightly: "You are Aiden, the one who followed Tyrian back in the days of the Vanished Fleet."

"That's me," Aiden broke into a grin. "You still remember me?"

"I don't," Duncan shook his head. "Sorry, I have forgotten most things. Subspace damaged my memories. I only heard about you and the other

first-generation Seafarers of the Sea Mist Fleet from other people."

"Please don't apologize, don't apologize," Aiden looked even more flustered. He shook his head and said: "It's… it's enough that you could come back. Everyone really missed you."

"They should be quite afraid, I think?" Duncan glanced around the hall with a smile. Many eyes dodged in fear as his gaze passed. "It's fine. Right now I'm only using an avatar form. If my true body came here, most sailors probably wouldn't be able to work in peace."

"More than half the people here are 'second-generation', and they really are scared of you," Aiden said, scratching at his shirt buttons in embarrassment. "After all, their first contact with you…"

"I know. The encounter at Frostholm fifty years ago." Duncan let out a slow breath and said it casually. As his words fell, Tyrian walked over quickly.

"The submersible is ready, Father."

"Oh, looks like it's time to go."

A smile appeared on Duncan's face. He rose from the chair and walked with Tyrian toward the platform that held the submersible in place. The diving apparatus, which carried the wisdom and hard work of countless people, was already waiting in silence—

The round hatch on its side was already open. Lights shone through the thick watertight chamber, lighting up the inside of the sphere. It did not look spacious. Aside from the many confusing pipes, valves, and control panels, the space left for people to move looked like it could hold at most three or four people.

Duncan gave the submersible a once-over, then stepped forward.

But in the next second he suddenly stopped, as if sensing something, and looked toward one side.

A spinning Ashen Wind suddenly rushed into the hall. It whirled rapidly over to the submersible's platform and condensed into shape in front of Duncan, Tyrian, and the others.

Agatha stepped out of the Ashen Wind. She still wore that black long dress, with her hair hanging loose, dressed like a Blind Nun.

"I want to go with you."

She did not waste words. She walked up to Duncan and spoke directly.

"You want to dive as well?" Duncan looked at Agatha in some surprise. "Why?"

"Because I want to 'see' with my own eyes what is really under Frostholm," Agatha said calmly and firmly. "As the protector of this city, I cannot stay in the safe great Cathedral and just wait for your results, and besides…"

She suddenly stopped. After a few seconds of silence, she lifted her head. Through the thick black cloth, her "gaze" fell on Duncan's eyes.

"Besides, this is a city of the people of Frostholm, and a matter for the people of Frostholm. In the submersible we built, there should be at least one person from Frostholm. Just think of it as… letting me go down in place of Governor Winston and all the past governors of Frostholm to take a look."

"Those are good reasons, and you should already know the risks of doing this. Since you are prepared, I won't try to talk you out of it," Duncan said with a nod. Then he turned his head and looked at Tyrian.

Tyrian reacted at once and said: "By design the submersible can hold up to four people, so two inside is certainly fine, but…"

“It’s all right. I don’t need to breathe either,” Agatha said softly, cutting him off.

Tyrian froze for a moment, then stepped back. “All right, then there is no problem.”

Duncan smiled. He walked to the hatch of the submersible, turned, and reached out a hand to Agatha: “Good. Let’s go.”

He and Agatha climbed into the submersible. The heavy round hatch then slowly closed.

Two strong Undying sailors stepped onto the platform and tightened the hatch locks from the outside.

Thick steel sealed the inside of the submersible off from the outside world. The narrow crew compartment grew quiet. Only a few machines and pipes still gave off a faint humming now and then.

There were no seats in the crew compartment, so Duncan and Agatha stood in front of the control panel, holding the iron pipes on either side that served as railings. Through the thick, sturdy glass portholes set into the nearby bulkhead, they could see the Undying sailors around the platform loosening the steel cables that held the submersible and releasing the safety pins on the sides of the steel frame.

Tyrian’s voice came from a small device in the corner of the submersible’s control panel: “Father, Lady Agatha, can you hear me?”

Duncan stepped up to the controls. “Yes. Very clearly.”

“All right. I won’t say much about how to handle the submersible. Its functions are actually very simple, so you shouldn’t have trouble. I’ll talk about what happens after you enter the water.

“The submersible is powered by a small steam core and a generator linked to that core. In theory this is enough to run until all Deep Dive tasks are done. But if the steam core or the generator fails, there are also two batteries in the bottom of the hull. They can keep the submersible running for about two more hours…

“There are three sets of high-powered searchlights outside the hull, but in the Deep Sea their effect is limited, so please be careful when you steer. The resistance on the sea floor is also very strong. The drive system can only move the submersible slowly, so you need to keep that in mind too…

“The communicator on the submersible has an effective range of only three hundred meters. Once you go deeper than three hundred meters, we won’t be able to talk like this anymore. But your power, or Lady Agatha’s Psychic Resonance, should not be affected.

“And also… maybe I’m worrying too much, but even for you, please be careful of the dangers in the Deep Sea—once you notice anything wrong, rise to the surface at once. The lever at the top left of the control panel is for an emergency ascent. Pull it and it will drop the ballast structure at the bottom of the submersible and open the buoyancy spheres on both sides of the hull… In the worst case, just abandon the submersible. With your power, you can take Lady Agatha and simply Teleport back. We can always build another machine…”

Duncan listened carefully to Tyrian’s reminders.

To be honest, this former Frost Sea pirate lord really was a bit long-winded. Many of his warnings did not seem necessary to Duncan.

But Duncan still listened patiently to every word Tyrian said. Only after the other man’s voice finally trailed off did he speak in a low voice: “I understand. Let’s begin.”

Outside the submersible, at the command seat at the far end of the hall, Tyrian took a slow breath, then nodded to the subordinates beside him.

“Open the sea valves!”

“Flood the channel!”

“Disconnect the external cables to the submersible. Prepare to release the hooks!”

A deep rumble passed through the submersible’s steel shell, echoing faintly in the spherical cabin. A slight vibration rose from under their feet, mixed with the creaking and scraping sounds from the hull outside.

The sea valves opened. Seawater surged quickly up the tunnel beneath the facility that led straight to the open sea, slowly rising to the set level. The last two steel cables above the submersible began to groan and slowly paid out.

Duncan and Agatha first felt a sway, then a drop. After a brief moment of weightlessness, the submersible entered the water. They began to slide down the slanted tunnel and, under the guidance of a series of mental guidance rails, moved quickly toward a sea outlet near the outer edge of South Port.

Outside the porthole, seawater rose up, then slowly sank into darkness. In that darkness they could only sometimes see flashes of light. Those flashes came faster and faster, and the shaking of the submersible grew stronger as well—until at last all the vibrations faded away.

Outside the porthole, only an endless deep blue remained, slowly growing dim.

There was still sunlight shining down through the water above, casting bands of light outside the window that moved and shifted between bright and dark. In the water that was slowly dimming, bubbles rose from the hull.

In the glow of the remaining sunlight, they looked like some kind of sea creatures wrapped in a dreamy light.

Agatha seemed drawn to the “view” outside the porthole.

She slowly left the helm, holding onto the handrail as she moved to the porthole. She leaned in with curiosity. Through the thick black cloth, her now empty eyes “stared” in a daze at that deep blue that was quickly sinking into darkness.

“What can you see?”

As Duncan got used to the levers and buttons on the control panel, which were not very complicated, he turned his head and asked casually.

“Light. All kinds of tiny lights,” Agatha said softly, as if talking to herself and as if lost in a trance. “They flow like rivers and form huge, complex currents that are still full of order… But outside has already fallen into darkness now, hasn’t it?”

“There’s still a bit of sunlight left, but it will be completely dark soon,” Duncan said as he slowly turned the submersible. “How about now?”

“An incredibly huge ‘curtain of light’, faint but filling my whole sight,” Agatha said. There was a hint of shock in her voice. “What is that?”

“It’s Frostholm,” Duncan said calmly. Through the porthole, in the weakening sunlight and the beam of the submersible’s powerful searchlights, he saw an extremely wide, rough, and mottled “cliff” standing quietly in the seawater. “It’s the city’s ‘base’.”

Chapter 477: Underwater Voyage

Under Duncan's somewhat clumsy but careful control, the submersible slowly adjusted its heading.

The "base" beneath the city-state of Frostholm was like a wide, endless, rough, and strange sea cliff, slowly moving past in the dim water outside the porthole.

The sunlight falling from the sea surface above had already faded. In the water, only the beams from the three large searchlights in front of the submersible remained. Those beams cast huge patches of light on the "cliff" surface. Beyond those bright spots was nothing but unknown darkness.

A low humming and the hiss of valves that adjusted the pressure by themselves sounded in their ears from time to time. These dull, lifeless noises instead made them feel all the more… alone.

That was the loneliness that came when one person left the group, when the mind left the borders of civilization. It was the unease of sinking little by little into endless darkness, wrapped on all sides by boundless seawater.

Agatha grew quiet. She stood by the porthole and "stared" in one direction outside for a long time. After who knew how long, she finally broke the silence and said softly: "All the light is fading… but I can still 'see' the base of the city. It is still giving off a very, very faint light. It is the only thing I can see in this darkness."

The world she observed was clearly not the same as that of an ordinary person.

“Do you know what I’m thinking about?” Duncan’s voice suddenly came from behind her.

“What are you thinking about?”

“I’m thinking that this might be how we look at the world,” Duncan said in a low voice, as if his words were blending into the humming of the machines around them. “The mortal world is like the sea. If we see all of civilization as one whole, then we are like this, sailing through a boundless sea abyss.

“Unknown darkness covers the whole world. From the lights of civilization, we carefully peek at the scenes that sometimes rise out of that darkness. We try to guess and piece together the shape of the whole world from those images that flash by. Yet we almost never have the chance to really know the full truth behind those lights and shadows—

“Behind one small fallen leaf there may be a whole forest. Behind one hard stone there may stand an entire mountain. A single vine slipping past in the lamplight may be only one outstretched tentacle of some mythical giant beast. Outside the faint light is the unknown. Even inside the faint light, what we see is only the shallow impression that the truth shows us at a certain place and a certain time.

“And as we make this careful voyage, there are some people who, by accident, look past the lights. They go mad. Some people try to widen the light. We call them pioneers. Many times there is not even a clear line between these pioneers and a Madman. As for the rest, they gather inside the ark of ‘civilization’, gather within the limited lights that are just enough to shine on the ground under their feet. They lower their heads and carefully draw back their gaze.

“They are called ‘ordinary people’.

“The part of the world that can be known and measured gives them a precious sense of safety, so they can no longer look toward the darkness outside the ark. But it is exactly these ordinary people, who make up most of the whole and are weak and powerless, who keep the whole ark running and even support those pioneers and Madmen.”

The sound of seawater being pumped into the ballast tank came from under their feet. The submersible slowly changed its angle and began to dive faster. In the window ahead, within the area lit by the searchlights, the uneven cliff kept rising upward. In the next second, the scene in that patch of light might turn into a stretch of empty dark water… or it might not.

Duncan drew back his gaze and looked around him.

Lights from the cabin ceiling shone down, bathing everything inside the submersible. After gazing at the darkness outside for too long, turning back to look at this cozy cabin really gave a deep, heartfelt sense of relief.

But the occasional creaks that came from somewhere on the hull never stopped reminding the people in the crew compartment that between this bright, comfortable cabin and hundreds of millions of tons of seawater outside, there was only one thin spherical shell of steel.

This fragile spherical steel shell had been hammered out piece by piece by countless ordinary people. Those artificers, who might never step even half a pace beyond the city-state in their whole lives, used their skill and wisdom to send this simple submersible down into the endless sea abyss beneath the city.

Agatha stayed silent for a long time before she spoke softly: “Actually… sometimes I feel lucky that my eyes can now see more than those of an ordinary person. Just like you said, we are all sailing in a boundless darkness. My eyes can now see a little farther into places where the light

does not reach. But I also often feel frustrated, because compared to this endless darkness, that little bit of extra sight seems meaningless…”

“Yes. For this boundless sea, seeing a little farther is indeed hardly anything,” Duncan said softly. Then he changed his tone. “But for us, who are sailing in the darkness, even being able to see one meter farther is of great importance.”

He casually switched off the main lights in the cabin, leaving only the necessary lights on the control panel.

The inside of the submersible dimmed. Yet, with the contrast in lighting, the beams from the powerful searchlights outside seemed even brighter in the darkness beyond the porthole. Within those patches of light, the details on the surface of the “cliff” also grew clearer.

“The world you describe is almost hopeless, yet your attitude always seems optimistic,” Agatha said. “That… surprises me a little.”

“I describe a hopeless world to you because the world is indeed that bad,” Duncan said casually. “My attitude is optimistic because I am an optimistic person. We can’t change this world, but our ‘attitude’ belongs to us.”

“I didn’t expect you to have this kind of personality, and I didn’t expect you to be so sensitive,” Agatha said, and a faint smile seemed to appear on her face. “Yes, I keep forgetting by accident that you were once the greatest explorer in this world.”

Duncan only smiled and did not answer. His gaze fell on the scene outside the porthole. Using the beams from the searchlights, he carefully watched the “cliff” that was slowly rising.

It looked like stone in texture, with parasitic growths on its surface that were like seaweed and coral.

But such a vertical structure, such a neat “base”, did not seem like something that formed naturally no matter how he thought about it.

He steered the submersible forward with care and stopped at a very close distance. Then, a little clumsily, he found a certain control lever on the panel and released the mechanical arm mounted at the very front of the submersible.

In the light, the mechanical arm slowly unfolded. The sharp tool at its end touched the “cliff” ahead and tapped and scraped it lightly.

Some fragments slowly fell through the water.

But inside those fragments there seemed to be an even harder structure.

“I have always been curious about one thing,” Duncan suddenly said, breaking the silence. “For so many years, in so many city-states, people have always dug deep underground—whether for mining, building underground facilities, or just for research. Has no one ever dug through this ‘base’?”

Agatha paused. The question seemed a bit out of place to her, but after a short moment of thought she shook her head. “As far as I know… there has never been such a case of ‘digging through’. The underground is dangerous. The lower you go below sea level, the higher the chance that strange changes appear in the darkness. Even with the protection of steam and fire, spiritual corruption and bizarre accidents in the mines happen every year. Not to mention anyone who would dig downward with the crazy idea of ‘boring through the city-state’ itself. And besides…”

She paused again to sort through her memories, then went on: “And even for those who really did dig down with such a crazy idea, it seems no one has ever succeeded. I once heard that the Academy of Truth tried this. Their conclusion was that, once you reach a certain depth, the drill can no longer

go any farther. The deeper you go, the harder it becomes, until even the toughest, most advanced drill bits all break."

"The deeper you go, the harder it gets?" Duncan frowned and turned to look at the mechanical arm that was tapping on the "cliff" outside the porthole. It had already knocked off some of the growths on it. After those loose fragments fell away, the inner layer of the cliff showed a darker, denser structure.

He could not tell whether it was rock or metal.

But its surface seemed to have faint, regular patterns on it, like… the ridges and grooves on the skin of some living creature.

Duncan worked the mechanical arm, trying hard to scrape some samples from that dense black layer, but it was all in vain.

The arm did not have enough power, and that black material was even harder than he had thought… was it some kind of "shell"?

All sorts of guesses rose in Duncan's mind. He even came up with some bold plans for probing it. But in the end he forced down his curiosity and began steering the submersible onward into the Deep Sea.

After all, his main goal on this trip was to explore the "Colossal Unknown Entity" directly beneath Frostholm. When he did not even know if there would be a second chance to make a Deep Dive, he could not waste the submersible's precious operating time halfway there.

With more noise coming from the ballast tanks, the submersible kept diving.

After an unknown length of time, they finally passed the "fault" beneath the city's base.

Very suddenly, the “cliff” inside the range of the searchlights came to an abrupt end. That huge patch of light seemed to be swallowed by darkness all at once, and an endless mass of dark water rushed in to take its place.

Even the strongest searchlights could not find anything to shine on in such empty, boundless water. Duncan could only see a vague edge where the light faded, stretching away outside the porthole. Inside the light and outside it, there was not a single point of reference.

This feeling of being buried in a huge darkness and sinking ever deeper was far more oppressive than facing that strange Great Hollow deep in the Boiling Gold mine.

Agatha also gripped the handrail in front of her a little more tightly in nervousness.

The last faint light in her “field of vision” had vanished.

Chapter 478: It Looked Down on the Abyss

The submersible had already passed beyond the “bottom” of the city-state. The boundless dark water replaced the rough vertical “cliff” from before. The beam from the high?power searchlight stretched endlessly through the sea, and nothing could be seen within its range.

Only from time to time did tiny flashes appear in the beam. They were drifting bubbles or bits of “debris” falling from above, catching and reflecting the light in the water.

Duncan turned a crank on the control console. The sound of water flooding into the ballast tank turned into a low rumble. He slowed the submersible’s descent and carefully raised its nose at a slight angle.

After crossing that boundary, he wanted to “look back” and gaze upward, to see what the city-state’s foundation really looked like.

The beam swept slowly through the darkness. Something so huge it took his breath away emerged from the endless water. An indescribable weight pressed in with that upside?down “rock layer” hanging above. Even without any supernatural forces causing mental corruption, this sight alone was enough to make most ordinary people feel crushed, even hurt in spirit.

The “foundation” of the city-state of Frostholm appeared outside the porthole. It was as if the land itself was hanging upside down. Under that crushing, sky?filling view, he saw countless jagged structures. They looked like clusters of stalagmites, or a forest of spires. Among the many uneven

protrusions, tens or even hundreds of meters tall, there were also things like sticky strands stretched between the “stalagmites”.

Yet in the middle of that shock and pressure crashing over him, what rose stronger in Duncan’s heart was a restless curiosity. He steered the crude little diving machine with care and actually headed toward that jagged, twisted upside?down “forest”.

At the same time, on the Vanished, Duncan had already reached the captain’s cabin and pushed open that door of the Lost Ones.

Zhou Ming walked into his studio apartment and, without surprise, saw a new piece in his collection glowing faintly on the table—the delicate “model” of the city-state of Frostholm.

He walked up to the table, picked up the lifelike city model with both hands, and studied every detail. Then he flipped it over to look at the structure on its underside.

The dense, complicated bumps there looked like some kind of tentacles that had degenerated and been laid out in messy rows. Or, to put it more boldly, like some sort of limbs.

Compared to only using the flames to sense the city’s underlying structure, this Deep Dive had given Zhou Ming far more detail.

He slowly closed his eyes, feeling the information coming from another world. He felt the trembling of the submersible, and the grand, shocking “scenery” slowly moving past its portholes.

This unremarkable steel contraption was passing between two “stalagmites” that were probably one to two hundred meters long. The searchlight’s beam swept over the jagged clusters of protrusions farther away, helping Duncan find a relatively safe path through.

This was a scene never mentioned in the records of the Abyssal Trench Project. Neither in the information Tyrian had provided, nor in the dossiers left in City Hall, was there any note of a submersible sailing through an “upside?down forest” at the city’s foundation.

Perhaps the pioneers back then had focused all their attention on the Deep Sea and never did such “extra” things. Perhaps this grotesque, upside?down mass had seemed too dangerous in the dark, so none of the early submersibles chose to venture into it. Or perhaps…

Perhaps someone had done so before, but no one had ever brought the truth they saw back to the surface.

The searchlight’s beam swept across another patch of darkness.

Something appeared in Duncan’s field of view.

In the next second, he yanked a lever on the console. The sudden reversal of the propeller produced a jolt that made the inside of the submersible creak and groan. The fragile steel sphere shuddered in the deep water. With the terrible sound of its mechanisms taking the strain, it finally came to a stop, almost crashing into a nearby “stalagmite”.

Agatha asked in a panic: “What happened?”

She looked up toward the porthole, but saw only many upside?down, scattered points of light outside. Among them was a larger luminous core. It gave off a hazy glow, and she could not make out any detail inside it.

Duncan did not answer at once. He only stared fixedly out the porthole, at what had just emerged from the darkness…

A huge, pale eye.

An eye. An eye wide open, set between those black protrusions that clustered like tentacles. Its diameter might have reached a hundred meters,

making the little submersible in front of it look like a single grain of gravel.

The eye had no life in it. It looked as if it had died hundreds or even thousands of years ago, in some far older age. Pale and hollow, it was set into the bottom of the city and hung upside down outside the porthole. It seemed to still calmly gaze down on the endless, deep dark seabed below, even in its last moments of dying. And now the submersible hovered before its dead pupil, as if receiving this ancient, decayed divine gaze.

Duncan finally broke the silence and said softly: “It is an eye.”

He turned his head and looked out through the porthole on the other side, checking other directions.

The spill of light from the searchlamp lit up the surroundings. He saw those black “stalagmites” hanging upside down in the water. Now he could finally be sure: these things really were limbs.

They were tentacles that had mutated, degenerated, and then lost all life.

These tentacles drooped in the seawater like withered vines hanging from a cave ceiling.

Agatha gripped the handrail hard. Even though her heart had long stopped beating, she still felt as if something in her chest was about to burst out. When she realized what she had just heard, when she understood what those faint lights in front of her really were, she felt a suffocating pressure she had not felt in a long time. She stammered: “You… you mean…”

“The city-state was built on some kind of massive creature,” Duncan said slowly. He was also shaken by what he saw, but he forced himself to calm down and sort out his thoughts. “At least… there are still some traces of it being a living thing.”

Agatha could not speak for a long time. After a long while, she finally managed to put words together amid her shock and confusion: “Is it…

dead?”

She lowered her voice without thinking, as if she was afraid that speaking too loudly would wake that unimaginable, unknowable “creature”.

“It should be dead,” Duncan said. At the same time, he carefully steered the submersible, slowly moving away from the huge pale eye. His movements were very cautious. Even though he was almost sure this giant creature was dead, he could not help but imagine something horrible, as if the moment the submersible made any sudden move, that eye would suddenly turn. “And in theory, it should not look like this. This does not fit any biological rule… it looks more like a twisted corpse, or something built out of a corpse as raw material…”

Agatha did not answer. She did not know whether she should marvel that Captain Duncan could still analyze things calmly in such a situation, or marvel at whether a creature large enough to carry a city even needed to “follow biological rules” at all. The sheer chaos and shock filled her heart so much that she could not think about these questions the way she usually did.

The worldview she had built up over so many years was being put to the test.

The true form beneath the cities was so twisted and terrifying. The only safe shelter Mortals had in the Boundless Sea was built on top of an unnameable creature. Under everyone’s feet, under rock and soil thousands of meters deep, withered tentacles hung down into the Deep Sea, and a pale eye looked down at the sea trench. And no one knew anything about it.

After staring blankly for who knew how long, Agatha finally came back to herself. She turned to Duncan and asked hesitantly: “Is only Frostholm like this?”

She did not know why she had to ask Captain Duncan this question. She had not even thought she would get any answer. It was just that the chaos in her heart pushed her to speak, even though the question was doomed to have no clear conclusion.

But the captain answered.

“Maybe all the city-states are like this,” Duncan said slowly. He remembered that time he had ‘sensed’ what lay under Pland. At the same time, from another point of view, he was studying the “collectible” on the shelf in his studio apartment. “Under Pland there are structures similar to these too—but there is no eye. In the place that should match it, there is only a swollen, deformed mass.”

In her shock, Agatha blurted out: “You have dived under Pland before?”

Duncan shook his head: “No. This is my first time diving into the Deep Sea in person. But I have other methods that let me roughly sense what lies under a city-state.”

As he spoke, he raised his head and looked at the upside?down “forest” that hung in the darkness outside the porthole.

Rough sensing always had its limits. If he had not come down to see it with his own eyes, he might never have guessed that the jagged, strange structures under the cities were actually unnameable remains.

The huge pale eyeball was slowly receding from view. The beam from the searchlight slid over the tentacles around it. Yet even as the eye sank back into the dark, the feeling of being under its long divine gaze clung to Duncan’s mind, like countless invisible feelers coiling around the submersible’s hull from all directions.

Even the running of the steam core seemed to grow heavy and sluggish.

But it was all an illusion. The submersible kept moving steadily away from that “forest” and that eye. Nothing was really stopping it.

“We still have to keep diving,” Duncan said, turning to Agatha. “The truth about the city’s ‘foundation’ is only the beginning. We are stepping into a blind spot outside the civilized world’s sight. Anything could appear next. Do you still have the courage for it?”

Agatha also turned her head. Through the black curtain, she met Duncan’s gaze calmly.

“I am ready,” the city-state’s Guardian said in a steady voice. “Let’s keep going down.”

Chapter 479: “People”

With the low rumble coming from the ballast tank, the submersible passed beneath that upside?down, dead world and kept diving toward an even more unknown and more dreadful abyss.

The forest of tentacles hanging from the bottom of the city and that huge pale eyeball vanished completely from the searchlight’s beam. Endless open dark water once more filled the view outside the porthole. Only the small points of light that sometimes floated up from the depths of the dark—bubbles or drifting motes catching the light—reminded Duncan that he was inside a submersible sailing through the sea, and not floating in empty, lonely outer space.

But he could not help making a strange comparison. If he only thought about them as “unknown and secretly terrifying”, what real difference was there between empty outer space and the dark Deep Sea filled with billions of tons of water?

The steam core drove the propellers. A low noise came from the machinery compartment. The row of pressure gauges in front of the control console hissed now and then, showing the submersible’s current state. Duncan slowed the descent to keep sudden pressure changes from damaging the hull, then turned his head and looked at the silent Gatekeeper standing beside him.

“Agatha, what are you thinking about?”

“I am thinking… when the pioneers carried out the Abyssal Trench Project, did they also see what we saw?” Agatha said slowly. “The truth under the city, the unnameable remains, the tentacles and the eyeball hanging down into the Deep Sea… Before the whole project went into a runaway state, in all those dives, was there really no one who, out of curiosity—or even just recklessness—looked back once at what was ‘above’?”

Duncan did not speak for a moment. In his mind, he recalled the secrets about the Abyssal Trench Project that he had once heard from Tyrian.

Even Frostholm’s General, who had once been deeply trusted by the Queen, seemed not to know the full shape of the Abyssal Trench Project. Had no one really discovered the truth under the city? Or had this truth, too terrible to face, been buried away, just like the secret in the Boiling Gold mine?

After a few seconds of silence, Duncan said softly: “Maybe someone really did look back. But what they saw was fated never to be written down. You are the Guardian of the City-State. You understand better than I do what this truth would mean.”

“…Many people would go mad,” Agatha said slowly. “Even without the forces of the Deep Sea acting on them, a single terrifying truth would be enough to trigger widespread nightmares and panic. Then those nightmares and that panic would take form and could link with the ‘truth’ under the city in ways no one could predict. In the worst case… ‘it’ might come back to life.”

“Mortals live in a dark sea full of horrors. Even the footing under their feet is built on twisted, grotesque remains. Dullness and blindness are the only grace all beings receive. They let most ordinary people stay far from truths that would drive them insane. And in most cases, so long as a truth is not noticed, it will never enter our Mortal Realm at all. But the key problem is that there are always ‘some cases’.”

“…Are you going to make our discovery public?”

“At least for now, I will not tell any ordinary person news this shocking. Most people’s calm, simple lives do not need to be disturbed by it. But there is a saying you must have heard—‘Once you know it exists, it has already become part of the fate of the mortal world.’”

Agatha nodded and said: “The second law of Anomalies and Visions: anything that has been known can never be erased. The truth under the city has already appeared before us. The link in fate has already been formed. We will have to deal with it again sooner or later.”

Duncan nodded lightly and said nothing more.

Just then, a strange, abrupt, low “thump?thump” sound suddenly echoed through the submersible, cutting off his and Agatha’s thoughts.

The sound… was like something knocking on the outside of the submersible’s hull.

Agatha was startled at once by the sound. She jerked her head up in shock and said: “Did you hear that? It sounded like someone knocking outside…”

Duncan also jumped at the sudden sound. But he quickly glanced at the gauges on the console, frowned a little, and said in a low voice: “It should be water pressure. The huge pressure of the sea is making the submersible’s hull deform slightly. Don’t worry. This is normal and still within the design limits.”

Agatha seemed a little calmer, but she still looked tense.

Diving in the dark Deep Sea was an experience she had never had before. Even as a Gatekeeper with great power, she could not help feeling weak and nervous inside. It was a feeling she could hardly imagine while standing on the safe surface.

Here, far from the civilized world, the Gods' divine blessing had already faded, and personal power meant very little. Between cold physical laws and unknown fate, there was only a narrow "gap". Inside that gap was survival. Outside it was nothing but bones. And what they could rely on in that gap… was only a single steel sphere.

And the "thump?thump" that kept coming from the submersible's hull kept reminding Agatha that, under the weight of billions of tons of water, it was as fragile as paper. What kept this shell from collapsing, besides the toughness of the steel itself, was only the delicate balance of its structure.

This was a kind of fear completely different from facing a heretic Eldritch God or a calamity born from a Vision. This kind of horror… was called "natural law".

Maybe it was because she was nervous. Maybe it was because the silence inside the submersible and the sounds outside made the air feel too heavy. After a few seconds of quiet, Agatha started looking for something to say. She watched Duncan working the levers and cranks and said: "You have quite a talent for handling machines. I thought you would ask Governor Tyrian to send an engineer who knew how to pilot this thing. I did not expect you to be so skilled with it."

"Skilled?" Duncan tilted his head a little. "But in fact I did not know how to operate it at all—at least, not before today."

Agatha said: "…Ah?"

"But none of Tyrian's people can pilot it either, not even the engineers who can read the blueprints," Duncan shrugged and went on. "They could only tell me, from the drawings, what each lever is supposed to do. Once you know what each lever does, their 'piloting skill' is the same as mine. No one knows how to run it. No one has ever run it. This thing was built by the governors of Frostholm. Its controls are completely different from those of

the submersibles from fifty years ago. And the people who truly understood it are all dead. That is the truth."

Agatha stared, her mouth half open, suddenly not knowing what to say.

Duncan noticed her reaction and smiled as he shook his head: "But I still have at least two advantages over them. First, I do not need to worry about safety. No matter how bad things get, I can return safely. Second…"

He paused and looked down at the control stick in his hand and the console in front of him.

Fine ghostly green flame moved between the gears and rods. Holy steam and oil soaked this huge, complex machine, and the glow of the spirit flame filled that steam and oil.

The steam core was like a powerful heart, obeying Duncan's every command.

Of course, it was not as "obedient and handy" as the Vanished. This soulless machine could only feed back some rigid, faint sensory signals at best. But that was already enough.

"Second, these machines are fairly obedient in my hands."

Agatha felt the flames flowing.

The flames filled the steel and oil around her. They flowed through the hissing steam and gears, running inside this soulless machine like blood, just like the flames that flowed in her own body. The two seemed to echo each other in a faint resonance.

That thin stream of spirit flame even made her feel a bit safer here at the dark, icy seabed.

She lowered her head slightly, as if saluting Duncan.

But Duncan did not pay attention to Agatha’s reaction. His focus had already returned to the work of piloting.

After all, even though the fire of his spirit form let him sense this machine’s state better, he still had to do the actual operation himself.

He had no choice. The first time he had been pushed onto the helm of the Vanished, he had never captained a ship either. He had already grown used to this rhythm of life where, even if he did not know how some thing worked, he could only grit his teeth and charge ahead…

Just then, another knocking sound suddenly came from outside the hull—

“Thud.”

It was short and clear, like bumping into something, faintly different from the earlier “knocking” on the hull.

Agatha noticed the strange sound at once and said: “There it is again… is the hull deforming too?”

But Duncan suddenly frowned and put his hand on another lever.

“It does not sound like that… it is something else.”

He clearly felt that something really had hit the submersible’s hull. It had bumped it from below.

A hum of machinery came from inside the submersible. Outside the porthole, the searchlight swung slowly through the pitch?dark water. The propellers spun, adjusting the submersible’s heading.

At last, something appeared in the light outside the porthole.

A person.

Something that looked like a human… shape.

Agatha “saw” it at once. That human-shaped outline suddenly appeared in her sight, giving off a living faint glow, just like other people she saw on the surface.

Only this glow was a bit dimmer and much paler.

She let out a low cry: “Ah!”

Even Duncan’s eyes widened at once, and an “oh damn” almost slipped out of his mouth.

In the Deep Sea nearly a thousand meters down in the Boundless Sea, directly under the city-state of Frostholm, a person suddenly floated into the submersible’s porthole. The impact of that sight was almost no less than the forest of tentacles at the city’s base and the pale, giant eyeball between them!

And right after that, as the submersible shifted position and the light swept around, an even stranger, more terrifying, even hair?raising scene appeared before Duncan and Agatha—

People. Crowds of “people”, packed thickly together, floating in this deep, dark, icy water!

Chapter 480: Blueprint

As the submersible’s lights swept around, all the shapes drifting in the dark water came into Duncan’s view—people, countless people, floating in the sea.

However, as Duncan looked more closely, he noticed something strange about these bodies.

They had no facial features, not even clearly defined hands and feet, and no clothes at all—just one shape after another with a rough human outline. Their surfaces had a coarse texture and a pitch?black color.

They looked like dolls crudely pinched out of black mud, like Rough Husks.

Duncan described the details he saw to Agatha.

“Only an outline?” Agatha sounded both shocked and unsure. “But in my eyes… they shine with the same Spiritual Insight glow as living people in the city?states…”

Duncan said nothing. He only frowned slightly and carefully guided the submersible toward one of the “human shapes” floating not far outside the porthole.

As the submersible’s movement stirred the water, it disturbed the calm of the Deep Sea. The pitch?black Humanoid Husk slowly rolled in the water, turning at an angle. Its smooth, spherical “head” faced the porthole first,

followed by its short, bare arms, which looked as if they had never been finished.

The mechanical arm slowly reached out. The hook at its tip caught onto the figure’s torso and gently prodded it.

It gave no reaction at all, showing no sign of being “alive”.

Duncan lifted his head again and looked out through the porthole at the distant, silently floating Humanoid Husks. In the beam of light they stretched farther and farther away until they finally vanished into the darkness of the Deep Sea.

How many were there here? Thousands? Tens of thousands? Or even tens of millions?

Suddenly a memory surfaced. Duncan recalled one detail he had heard when he once discussed the Abyssal Trench Project with Tyrian—the No. 3 submersible had shot crazily upward during its final Deep Dive, and the explorer who had gone mad kept screaming one sentence after they returned to the sunlight above:

“We all died down there!”

Duncan furrowed his brow little by little and looked gravely at the countless bodies drifting silently outside the porthole—was this what that explorer had seen before he lost his mind?

Beside him, Agatha suddenly broke the silence. Her tone turned serious: “This makes me think of those replicas that infiltrated the city?states before.”

“I thought of that too,” Duncan nodded slightly, “but they are not quite the same. Those replicas might show all kinds of inhuman traits, but at least they have faces, hands, feet, and other details. They also try to imitate humans, wearing normal clothes. These Humanoid Husks, though, only

have the most basic outline. If anything… they look more like Rough Husks, even cruder than the replicas."

"Some kind of unfinished product?" Agatha suddenly thought of something. "Were those replicas 'manufactured' out of these Rough Husks as a base?"

"Hard to say," Duncan replied, his tone uncertain. "These things might have been drifting in the Deep Sea for many, many years. At the very least, they were already here when the Abyssal Trench Project began. Also, the power that invaded the city?states used the properties of the mirror world to intrude into the Mortal Realm, while these here are 'physical' bodies in the Deep Sea. The two are connected, but they shouldn't be in a simple unfinished?versus?finished relationship."

Agatha listened, deep in thought. For some reason, she suddenly recalled something a cultist had said when she confronted them before—

"There were never any replicas to begin with. Or rather… we are all replicas…"

Almost at the same time, Duncan seemed to think of something as well. His gaze passed over the floating bodies and turned toward the unknown Deep Sea below. Then he reached for the control lever.

Deep in the machinery bay, some device let out a dying growl and wail. The hull creaked under the unbearable strain. As the sound of water flooding in rose, the submersible began to descend again.

As those almost terrifying noises echoed around them, Agatha could not help looking at Duncan: "Captain, can this thing still hold together?"

Duncan's gaze swept over the instruments on the control panel. At the same time he sensed the faint feedback from the fire of his spirit form. His hand, pulling the dive lever, did not relax.

"It can still hold," he said in a low voice. "We should be almost there."

“Almost there?” Agatha froze. “You know what’s down below?”

Duncan did not answer. He just kept carefully guiding the submersible downward, making tiny adjustments to the thrusters. The hull, pushed to its limits, let out bone?chilling creaks almost every second. Even the edges where the portholes joined the hull began to groan and crack, as if the fragile balance might break at any moment and the entire submersible would crumple into a wad of metal under the pressure of the sea.

Yet it kept diving, moving along that narrow knife?edge between collapse and balance, sinking toward the deepest darkness.

But the hull and machinery were not the only sources of dreadful sound. There was another noise even more chilling—the steady, real thuds striking the outside of the hull:

“Bang.” “Bang.” “Bang”…

The Humanoid Husks, those Rough Husks of black mud, bumped against the hull from time to time. The dull thuds sounded especially horrifying, like stones knocking against a skull.

Even Agatha could not help tightening her grip on the handrail in front of her.

She could feel the entire submersible tilting forward. The angle had reached the point where it was hard to stand without holding on.

Then she suddenly “saw” something appear outside the porthole.

A stretch of rolling, chaotic outline that seemed endless appeared at the edge of the searchlight beam, near the lower rim of the porthole.

It looked… almost like a stretch of ground.

“The seabed?” Agatha cried out in shock. “I see something… is that the seabed?”

Duncan stared silently out of the porthole with his gaze. He looked at the uneven “ground” that had suddenly appeared in the black Deep Sea, at its jagged, twisting “coastline” and the hazy structures farther away that he could not see clearly. Only after a long time did he shake his head slightly: “Not the seabed. We are still far from what you would call the ‘seabed’—that is a piece of land floating in the water.”

Agatha sounded puzzled: “A piece of land floating in the water?”

“…Another Frostholm Island,” Duncan answered softly. “We can only see a short stretch of coastline, but I know this terrain very well. That is the main island of Frostholm—Frostholm in its original form, without the city?state, without the harbor, without any buildings.”

Agatha’s body clearly trembled a little.

Duncan lifted his head and looked at the water around and above that “Frostholm Island”.

Countless Humanoid Husks floated around that “Deep Sea floating island”, like a swarm of bees around a hive.

And the scene was sealed in the dark, icy depths of the Deep Sea like amber, time frozen as if someone had pressed pause, quietly holding an ancient moment in place.

Agatha’s voice sounded beside him: “This place… what exactly is it…”

“…The original Blueprint,” Duncan said quietly.

In the third Long Night, the Crawling King bestowed the Blueprint upon the Collective and began the Genesis Protocol. To avoid repeating the fate of the King of Dreams and the pale giants, He divided that Blueprint, removed the kingdoms from the mortal world, and turned those kingdoms into twelve hundred cities…

After the third Long Night, civilization survived, and the Deep Sea era began. Everything in the Deep Sea era was built upon this “twelve? hundred?city” Blueprint of the Crawling King.

A portion of what was recorded in that Blasphemous Tome had just been confirmed.

But could there be another possibility?

Duncan’s thoughts churned, and he fell silent for a moment. Beside him, Agatha finally reacted. Once she understood what “original Blueprint” meant, she spoke in disbelief: “You mean… Frostholm as it is now, and the people of Frostholm, and even all the city?states and mortals in this world… were all manufactured based on these ‘things’ in the Deep Sea…”

“It’s one possibility,” Duncan said, shaking his head slightly, his voice low. “In the Annihilators’ heretical teachings, there is a record of the Abyssal Lord’s Work of Creation. Of course that is heresy. But we cannot deny that the ancient texts in their hands might still reveal part of the true history.”

Agatha opened her mouth but could not say a word.

From the moment she dove into the Deep Sea, the world as she knew it seemed to be undergoing an earth?shaking reshaping. Too many doubts, too many shaken beliefs made even a Gatekeeper with a steadfast mind struggle to sort out her thoughts.

The original island “templates” floating in the Deep Sea, the countless human?shaped Rough Husks… if what the Annihilators said about the Abyssal Lord creating the world was true, then… would that not mean all living beings in the mortal world were essentially creations of the Abyssal Lord?

Even after surviving the mirror world crisis in Frostholm and reaffirming her faith and conviction through that great trial, Agatha still found it hard to

accept such a reality?shattering “possibility”.

But she did not blindly deny everything she saw in the face of such huge contradictions and doubts.

From the moment she decided to undertake this Deep Dive, she had prepared herself mentally—

In the Deep Sea, anything was possible.

“Are we… going to get closer?” She turned her head and spoke to Duncan in as steady a tone as she could manage.

But Duncan did not touch the controls again.

His gaze swept over the many instruments on the console.

His senses spread throughout the submersible.

“…We’ve already reached the limit,” he said. “The submersible’s hull can’t hold.”

“…We were just a little short,” Agatha said, obviously full of regret. “We were about to reach that floating island…”

“It doesn’t matter. It’s only the submersible that can’t hold,” Duncan shook his head slightly and looked out the porthole. “There is something here that can.”

Agatha turned her head in confusion.

But Duncan kept quietly using his gaze to look outside, staring at those shapes drifting in the light… the Humanoid Husks.

“I remember you said just now that in your eyes, these Humanoid Husks, like Rough Husks, shine with a Spiritual Insight glow like living people.”

Outside the porthole, one of the roughly shaped Humanoid Husks slowly turned its head toward Agatha.

Chapter 481: Deeper in the Deep Sea

In that instant, strange and chaotic sensations suddenly flooded into Duncan’s mind. Just like during his past “Spirit Realm walks”, he felt his “viewpoint” split in two, and a brand?new shell became a new “end” through which he sensed the world. But… it still felt a bit different from before.

In his new “viewpoint”, restless streams of light filled everything like interference. Bands of light and shadow, bright and dark, spread through the water like scanning lines. He saw the distant “original landmass” shrouded in darkness, the countless Humanoid Husks floating around it, and at the same time he also saw the inconspicuous submersible—it was hovering above the Deep Sea floating island at a slant, maintaining a forward?tilted angle, pale light extending out from its front and slowly fading into the water.

All of this was wrapped in flickering, half?real light and shadow. Even in places beyond the submersible’s searchlights, he could still “see” outlines and faint glimmers. It was a completely new way of seeing.

Outside the porthole, in the Deep Sea, the shell that had suddenly begun to move slowly raised an arm and touched its own featureless head.

Of course, Duncan did not find his eyes—this body he had just taken over had no such organs. In fact, it did not even have fully formed hands and

feet. The bare ends of its limbs touched the smooth, flat face, and a rough, dull, oddly numb sensation came back to him.

Then, all of a sudden, Duncan had a feeling… Following that feeling, he controlled his new shell, stretched out both arms, and pressed hard on the body's "face".

The pitch?black, mud?like face with its smooth surface squirmed. Within a few seconds, the front of the face split and formed two eyes.

His vision became much clearer at once.

Somewhat clumsily, Duncan controlled this Rough Husk body and slowly swam to the front of the submersible, using his newly formed eyes to look inside.

He and himself stared at each other. The feeling was both novel and eerie.

Inside the submersible, Agatha could not help letting out a delayed cry: "Ah!"

Only then did she realize what had happened. She jerked her head toward Duncan, who was standing at the console: "You… really startled me."

"You should learn to get used to it," Duncan said inside the submersible without looking back, still watching the state of the machinery. "People around me are always a bit too easily spooked."

Agatha still had not recovered. Her whole body stayed tense, her "gaze" darting quickly back and forth between Duncan and the "human shape" outside the hull. Only one thought filled her mind—

[People in this world really did have good reason to fear Captain Duncan. Even in this endless Deep Sea, what he had just done so offhandedly was far too uncanny and terrifying.]

But after hesitating for a long time, she still did not dare say what was in her head aloud. She could only forcefully change the subject: “…What are you going to do next?”

“This temporary shell can see in the dark. I am going to keep checking what’s ahead,” Duncan said casually. At the same time, he had already begun to pull a series of levers and cranks on the console, and with his movements, the machinery bay of the submersible once again filled with strained noises on the verge of failure. “As for us… we need to rise a bit. This machine is about to give out. It can’t stay at its maximum depth for long.”

Amid the low roar of the ballast tanks struggling to pump out water, the submersible began to slowly rise. Yet Agatha still could not help staring out the porthole at that “human shape” slowly receding in the light.

A faint wisp of fire suddenly appeared in the water. The shell carrying Captain Duncan’s will waved toward them, then turned around and, wrapped in drifting spirit form flame, slowly sank into the depths of the darkness.

Cold. Dark. Lonely. Silent.

Duncan’s consciousness slowly adapted inside this temporary shell in its uncanny state. He turned the body, swam, moved forward through the darkness, and kept approaching the main island of Frostholm floating in the Deep Sea.

The submersible’s light had already receded, and darkness once more ruled this part of the Deep Sea. Yet the ghostly green fire of his spirit form spread slowly through the water. That faint glow, together with this body’s strange sensing abilities, let Duncan always make out his surroundings and the direction he was heading.

All around him, countless Humanoid Husks floated in the icy water.

It was like an extremely grotesque gathering. Rough Husks in the shape of “people” clustered on all sides, near and far, frozen and blind, rising and falling slightly with the currents. Only the one shell with eyes was moving through this silent, eerie “crowd”.

Duncan did his best not to touch the “human shapes” drifting near him, yet he still inevitably brushed past them at very close range.

Every time he passed them, he could not help imagining strange and terrifying things—as if there were countless pairs of eyes here, countless souls waiting to wake, curiously watching him, this uninvited guest, ready to reach out to him at any time.

But in the end, nothing happened.

Those silent human shapes just stayed silent. They had no mind and no soul, like hollow dolls piled together out of mud.

Duncan passed through these empty shells and reached a cliff on the edge of the “Deep Sea floating island”.

He stopped and studied the terrain in front of him.

This should be the southeastern coast of Frostholm. In the world above the surface, there was the harbor, warehouses, and the customs office near this stretch of shore. A pretty little Cathedral stood on the sea cliff, and hardy trees, evergreen in winter, lined the path leading up to the Cathedral.

But here, on the rugged coast, there were only bare rocks with a strange, pitch?black sheen, like rough models that had not yet been painted.

Duncan raised his head and looked toward the center of the Deep Sea floating island.

Between darkness and faint light, he could just make out some huge structure there, like a mountain peak or a giant pillar running through the island.

He thought of the scene Martha had shown him when they spoke before—

Countless minds, falling into the sea, had cast one last glance toward that dark abyss before they faded. The shared impression they had formed in their terror was a giant pillar running through a vast entity floating in the Deep Sea.

Now it seemed that the huge entity shown in that vision was this “original Blueprint” of Frostholm before his eyes. Then what about the giant pillar that pierced the island? Was it the Abyssal Lord who had “intruded” into the Mortal Realm? Or… the so?called replica?

Duncan thought for a moment, then set off swimming toward that “pillar”. But after only a short distance, he stopped again, feeling a bit troubled.

It was too far. It would be like crossing half a city?state.

A horse could die of exhaustion just trying to reach that distant mountain—let alone here in the Deep Sea, where movement was so hard.

Even if this body was unaffected by the crushing pressure of the Deep Sea, swimming all the way there would still be a slow and exhausting job.

As Duncan pondered, a thought slowly emerged.

After hesitating for a few seconds, he raised one arm in the water and gave it a light wave, deciding to try and see.

Ghost?green flame spread out with his motion and, in the blink of an eye, gathered into a spinning doorway. When the doorway opened, a skeletal bird wrapped in blazing fire burst out of it and circled Duncan, squawking loudly:

“Who is calling the fleet! teleportation successful! teleportation successful! Open up, delivery service!”

Duncan stared in stunned surprise, eyes wide.

AI flapped its wings beside him. In this Deep Sea, under the weight of hundreds of millions of tons of seawater, it still moved as lightly and freely as if it were flying in the sky. Its sharp female voice, unique and sounding like some kind of pitch?shifted synthetic tone, was just as noisy as ever, clear enough to drill straight into a person’s head.

The Deep Sea environment might as well not exist for AI!

Duncan had only intended to try, summoning AI to see if she could be of any use. After all, this pigeon’s “teleportation” ability had already shown unbelievable usefulness many times. But this was the Deep Sea, completely different from the surface. He had been ready to teleport AI back to the ship at once if she could not adapt to the environment. Yet what he saw now… was completely beyond his expectations.

He just stared, dumbfounded, as the pigeon flew around him as if it were in open air, squawking noisily. It moved through the water like a projection untouched by the environment. After staring for quite a while, he finally reached out a hand to stop the bird.

AI obediently landed on Duncan’s arm and tilted her head curiously: “Whatcha doing, whatcha doing, whatcha doing?”

Duncan was about to speak when he suddenly realized this body did not seem to have a mouth. Even if it had one, he did not know how to speak directly in the Deep Sea. So he focused his mind instead, trying to pass his thoughts to this pigeon spirit—

“This is the Deep Sea. Do you feel any discomfort?”

He fixed his gaze on AI’s eyes, wondering if she could understand him and waiting for her answer.

AI tilted her head again.

“GG, you came surfing too!” the bird suddenly flapped her wings in excitement. Sparks of ghostly green light scattered from between her bone wings. “Skywing 3G, so fast! Skywing 3G, so fast!”

Duncan’s expression shifted a little. He listened to the pigeon spirit’s noise, deep in thought, and did not speak for a long time.

Only when AI gradually quieted down and pecked his arm curiously did she speak again: “Application not responding?”

That finally jolted Duncan out of his thoughts, and his mind quickly returned to the matter at hand.

There was serious work to do.

He raised his head and looked at the distant, chaotic darkness ahead. Focusing his mind again, he tried to pass his command to the pigeon spirit beside him—

“Take me to that place.”

“Order received! Order received!” AI reacted at once. As always, she flapped her wings in excitement, making roaring flames surge around them. “Mission will be accomplished!”

Chapter 482: The Room

In the dark Deep Sea, a ball of ghost-green flame suddenly shot past like a meteor. The crushing weight and stillness of hundreds of millions of tons of seawater seemed not to exist at all. They did not slow that “meteor” in the slightest.

Ai streaked across the black floating island of the Deep Sea at lightning speed. She finally stopped over the island’s central area and drew her body together again out of the flames.

Duncan stepped out of the fire and floated in the water. He turned his head to look at the Pigeon Spirit flapping back and forth beside him.

Ai flew over and landed on her Master’s shoulder. She tilted her head in curiosity and asked: “What are you staring at?”

Duncan did not answer. He only lifted his arm and gently rubbed the pigeon’s head. Then he turned around and looked toward the huge “pillar” at the center of the island.

Now he stood before it. The shocking giant column rose in his view, stretching up from the mountaintop at the center of the Deep Sea floating island. It pointed almost straight toward the sky. It seemed not only to pierce the whole island, but to pierce the endless dark Deep Sea itself, reaching all the way up toward Frostholm, up into the world above the sea that bathed in sunlight.

But it did not truly extend without end. When he got close enough, Duncan finally saw more details, and he noticed that the upper half of this “pillar”

came to an abrupt stop in the water.

The break was very, very high above. There seemed to be a sudden, ugly fracture there.

But before he examined that break, Duncan first moved carefully toward the middle part of the pillar and studied the shape of its “outer skin”.

It was neat and dense. Faint complex, regular patterns could be seen on it, along with evenly spaced raised structures. This pillar, which looked like an enormous tentacle, showed an orderly, “tidy” feeling in its details. It even looked… like some kind of industrial product.

Duncan hesitated for a moment, then carefully reached his hand toward the pillar. This shell of a body had no formed hands or feet, but as he made the motion to touch the “pillar”, the end of his arm suddenly swelled and writhed. In almost the blink of an eye, it split and shaped itself into the structure of a hand.

Was this a second shaping based on some “original template”, triggered on its own by a special stimulus?

Duncan remembered the feeling from before, when the face of this body had split to form eyes. He guessed at it in his mind. At the same time, he felt his newly formed fingers touch the pillar’s pitch-black surface.

A rough, cold feeling came from his fingertips, like rubbing crude cast iron, yet it also seemed to have a certain softness.

Duncan leaned closer and examined the pillar’s surface more carefully.

Deep under that dull gray-black skin, he could faintly see pale blue lines, like veins buried deep under flesh.

Duncan’s heart stirred. He at once thought of that piece of “flesh” sample he had taken from Captain Cristo Barbelli’s mouth deep inside the

Obsidian.

The textures of the two looked very similar. Was this pillar standing in the Deep Sea really a limb of the Abyssal Lord stretching down into the Mortal Realm?

With a strange feeling inside, Duncan backed away a little and slowly swept his gaze over the giant pillar.

To find the wound Captain Cristo had left on a structure this huge was of course impossible for any mortal, but that did not stop a fresh wave of respect for the captain from rising in Duncan's heart.

A few minutes later, Duncan started to swim upward along the pillar. His target was that "break".

After a long time, he finally reached the place where the break lay, and what he saw there was almost what he had imagined.

The pillar did end abruptly here, as if some jagged sharp teeth had bitten it off. The edge of the break was uneven and ridged.

Inside the break, the gray-black inner wall sank in on itself, like a strange, eerie volcanic crater.

Duncan floated near the "break" and roughly estimated the pillar's scale from what he saw. He soon confirmed one thing—

If the "Great Hollow" in the Boiling Gold mine really was the result of a similar "pillar" or "tentacle" corruption, then the tentacle that had pierced into the city-state was far smaller than the pillar before his eyes. Its size might have been only one fifth of this one, or even less.

Was it because the tentacle that pierced the city-state was only a "projection of power" from this main body in the Deep Sea? Or was the tentacle in the Great Hollow still in its early growth and meant to keep growing?

If the defense of Frostholm had failed, if he had not managed to destroy Frostholm's mirror world in the end, and if the "pillar" in the Great Hollow deep under the Boiling Gold mine had kept growing out of control… would it have grown until it tore through the mine, burst through the mountain above, and become a "giant pillar" just like the one before his eyes now, as if it ran through a whole floating island?

Was this what those mad Annihilators claimed and longed for—to "recreate in the Mortal Realm the grand Blueprint of the Lord's creation"?

These frightening guesses flashed through Duncan's mind for a moment. Then a tiny glimmer of light suddenly shot past the edge of his vision and cut off his thoughts.

He snapped his head toward the place where that glimmer had appeared.

It was at the center of the "break", at the deepest point of that sunken "crater".

He hardly hesitated. He swam toward that spot at once.

He passed over the jagged broken "cliffs" at the pillar's edge and over the dark matter that sank toward the center. In this silent Deep Sea, far from the civilized world, that sudden flash of light became the only target in Duncan's eyes. He swam as fast as he could and reached the area near the center of the pillar's break.

Yet when he arrived, the flash had already vanished.

Only empty darkness remained here. The "ground" inside the pillar's break lay as cold and still as rock.

Duncan floated in the water, frowning as he looked across that darkness. The empty place felt like a solid, regretful ellipsis, hiding its secrets once more deep behind the Veil.

But soon, he noticed something wrong in what he saw.

Below him, at the center of the pillar's break, the "ground" had a faintly strange texture. It looked somewhat… "blurred".

Yes, blurred, as if it was not solid matter at all, but truly a layer of Veil between real and unreal.

Duncan hesitated for a few seconds, then carefully moved closer to that strangely textured "ground". But before he reached out to touch it, he first gathered a tiny flame at his fingertip and cast it into that blurred "Veil".

When in doubt, let the spirit flame clear the way. Being extra careful never hurt.

The eerie green spirit form fire dropped onto the black "ground" in almost an instant. At first it sank in and vanished, like water seeping into sand. Right after, faint threads of green flame started to spread through the darkness. In almost the blink of an eye, the entire "ground" was burning fiercely!

As the flames burned, Duncan suddenly felt that some subtle "connection" was forming.

But the link did not point to the huge pillar beneath him, the one that seemed to be an Elder God's tentacle. It pointed instead toward a presence that felt… vaguely familiar.

In the next second, he saw the ground below change quickly as the flames spread. It slowly turned into something like a mirror surface, and that mirror-like layer rippled faintly in the firelight, like a smooth, thick liquid!

Duncan's heart stirred. He followed the feeling that came from the flames and moved closer to the rippling, mirror-like "liquid surface", then reached out and touched it with a finger.

Boom!

In the unreal space, it felt as if a huge crash exploded inside his mind. Frozen time suddenly roared into motion. A heavy Veil tore open all at once. A wall at the edge of the Mortal Realm collapsed with a thunderous rumble. Duncan felt himself cross some boundary in an instant. Then the “world” before his eyes began to fill with warm light.

The feeling of being wrapped in cold, heavy seawater vanished at once. Solid ground under his feet replaced the empty, anchorless floating from a second earlier. The warm light before his eyes also grew softer. As his vision slowly adjusted, Duncan finally saw his surroundings, and he stared in stunned shock.

He was standing in a splendid, bright room.

Light poured from the chandelier on the ceiling, shining over many fine and tasteful furnishings. Shelves and metal statues in a courtly style glowed softly in the light. A magnificent large bed stood in the center of the room, wrapped in semi-transparent curtains, and it seemed that someone was sleeping in their depths.

Duncan stared at the scene before him in disbelief. Then he suddenly turned his head and looked behind him.

That seemed to be the direction he had come from.

He saw a mass of twisted, chaotic darkness.

The room seemed to vanish into thin air before that boundary. Beyond the broken, jagged walls and floor was a chaotic realm like a void. Twisted shadows and dim streams of light rose and flowed in that nothingness. It seemed full of Truth and mysteries enough to drive any mortal mad, yet it also seemed like a hollow with no meaning at all.

A word suddenly flowed into his mind—

Subspace.

Duncan felt his heart—if this body even had a heart—skip a beat. He had never imagined a scene like this. He stood in a shattered room, and just one step away lay Subspace with its chaotic lights and shadows. Those hazy, chaotic lights and shadows seemed to give a silent roar, using wild, wordless speech to pour into him incomprehensible knowledge and “Truth”.

Duncan raised his hand and carefully reached toward the darkness beyond the room’s edge.

His fingers met a hard, cold surface.

An invisible barrier stood between him and Subspace.

A voice suddenly spoke from behind him: “You cannot go through. You have not truly opened that door yet.”

Duncan’s heart lurched, and he whipped around.

The curtains around the splendid bed had already been drawn aside. The person who had been asleep on the bed had woken at some unknown time and was quietly watching him.

Silver-white long hair fell over her shoulders, and violet eyes shone like gems.

“Alice?”

Chapter 483: Frostholm Queen

At the center of that magnificent bed, the “master of the room” who had just woken up leaned against the pillows and studied Duncan, the uninvited guest, with curious eyes. That silver-white hair and those violet eyes were so familiar.

Duncan had blurted out the name “Alice” without thinking. The deep, hoarse “voice” that sounded like a dull echo came straight from the chest of this shell of a body.

But then he frowned a little. He woke from that instant of surprise and shock and looked thoughtfully at the lady.

She was not Alice. Though her face was exactly the same, her bearing was totally different. More importantly, Alice would not appear in a place like this. So the greater chance was that…

“Ray Nora,” Duncan guessed the woman’s identity. He looked into her eyes with a questioning gaze and spoke slowly: “Frostholm Queen?”

“It feels like a long time since I last heard that title,” the lady who had just awakened said with a smile. She adjusted how she leaned on the bed and looked at him with curiosity: “Who are you? How did you come straight into this room without opening that door?”

“Door?” Duncan frowned. Hearing her mention that word again stirred his curiosity, and he asked: “What door?”

The lady did not answer. She only raised a hand and pointed to a spot not far away.

Duncan looked in the direction of her finger and saw a closed door carved with complex patterns. It was clearly the bedroom's main door.

"Anyone who can come here is either a servant of this house or a guest who holds the key," she said calmly. "You are clearly not a servant of this house, and you do not have the key in your hand."

Duncan's heart gave a jolt—the key! She had just mentioned the key!

"The key you are talking about, is it a brass key used to wind up a doll?" He turned back, keeping his voice calm to hide every ripple in his feelings, and asked: "Are you really Ray Nora, Queen of Frostholm?"

"I am," Ray Nora said with a smile, and she shook her head slightly. "But you still have not answered my question—who are you?"

Duncan drew back the emotion in his eyes. As he quickly sorted his thoughts, he spoke at an unhurried pace: "You may call me Duncan."

He gave only his first name and did not mention the more famous family name. Yet when Ray Nora heard it, her eyes widened a little at once. Then an even brighter smile appeared on her face as she said: "Ah, so it is you—Captain Duncan, the legend. It makes much more sense that you could come into this room. But… I truly did not expect you to look like this."

Duncan paused at her words, then lowered his head and looked at his body.

It was still that extremely strange pitch-black human shape, like a rough husk the Creator had not yet had time to refine when making humans. This abstract form could not be called "friendly-looking" at all.

"This is only a temporary avatar form," Duncan said offhand, with a bit of awkwardness. Then he noticed something strange in her manner and asked:

“You do not seem very surprised. Did you already know I would come?”

“I did not know, but I lost the ability to feel ‘surprise’ many years ago,” Ray Nora said calmly. “If you always see too many things you should not see, if you learn all kinds of strange forms this world can take, always experience death before it comes, and fall into dreams before you truly sleep, then you will lose that ability sooner or later too…”

She smiled. Her light tone sounded as if she was only talking about the weather as she said: “Even if this world still holds things no one can foresee, numbness will let you face every surprise calmly.”

Duncan looked into Ray Nora’s eyes. Behind her calm attitude, he recalled all kinds of information about this Frostholm Queen—

It was said that Ray Nora was a born psionic. Her gift of Spiritual Insight let her speak with many unseen beings. People said she could even have Foresight of the future and know Truth out of thin air…

As he sorted this information in his mind, Duncan’s expression did not change. He walked over to one corner of the room, dragged a chair to the big bed, sat down, and looked seriously into the Frostholm Queen’s eyes: “I have many questions. I hope you can answer them.”

“I also have many questions,” Ray Nora said with a smile. “It has been far too long since I last talked with anyone. A Visitor is very precious to me—so if you are willing to answer my questions, I am willing to answer yours.”

“Very well, then I will not be polite,” Duncan said, getting straight to the point. “What exactly is this place? Why are you here?”

“Ah, such a hard question right at the start…” Ray Nora frowned, as if she truly struggled over how to put it into words. After a moment, she spoke slowly: “To explain it in a way that is easier to understand, this is a ‘drifting place’. It is not one fixed location. It is a ‘link’ between many places. Do

you see the darkness at the edge of the room? The view outside can sometimes change into other shapes—the right conditions can link it to the right ‘place’. But for me, it has only one use. It lets my dreams link to the Deep Sea under Frostholm.”

“Do you need me to explain what the Deep Sea under Frostholm is?” she asked.

“No need,” Duncan said with a shake of his head. “Keep going. Why are you here?”

“All right. It seems you already know what lies in the Deep Sea,” Ray Nora said with a soft breath. “I stay here to hold a dream and make sure the being in that Deep Sea keeps sleeping.”

Duncan’s eyes grew serious as he asked: “The Abyssal Lord?”

“…It seems you know more than I thought,” Ray Nora said, giving Duncan a quiet look. “But you are wrong. Though it indeed comes from that ‘Crawling King’, the being in the Deep Sea is not the true Abyssal Lord. Strictly speaking, it is only a replica.”

In a flash, Duncan remembered a line he had seen earlier in that strange “dark space”: “Cluster Controller has begun copying itself.”

So the giant “pillar” in the Deep Sea really was not the true body of the Abyssal Lord. It was only a replicant that had somehow appeared in the Mortal Realm!

So the exact situation was this: a replicant of an Elder God had pierced the “original city-state Blueprint” in the Deep Sea. The power that leaked out from it had caused all the later events. And the root of it all… was the Abyssal Lord’s complete runaway state?

Could he take it this way: before this replicant appeared in the Mortal Realm, the Abyssal Lord had not been in a runaway state at all? Had its

condition worsened bit by bit over long ages until it reached this point?

Then if he followed this line of thought further… what about the other deities? If the “terrible Eldritch Gods” in people’s eyes had also gone from stable to a runaway state, then what of the “Four Gods” in the mortal world? Would they also go into a runaway state? Or… had they already started to slip into that runaway state?

Duncan thought of Pland and Frostholm, both under the protection of the Storm Goddess and the God of Death, running into trouble one after another. He thought of Vision 001, which had already started to fail. This clear sign of large systems breaking down bit by bit—was it proof that the whole world was falling into a runaway state?

When that unresolved guess found confirmation, a flood of tangled thoughts rushed into his mind. In a heartbeat, Duncan linked them to the many events that had happened on the Boundless Sea during this time.

Right then, Ray Nora’s voice came again from the other side and cut off his storm of thoughts: “Now it is my turn to ask questions.”

Duncan quickly gathered his thoughts and put them in order: “Ask.”

“How did you come here?” Ray Nora asked. Curiosity filled her eyes.

“In the Deep Sea under Frostholm, I found that ‘replica’, and at its break point I found an ‘entrance’ that could lead here,” Duncan said without hiding anything. “As for how I came down this deep… I rode the city-state of Frostholm’s submersible.”

“A submersible?” Ray Nora frowned, but soon she seemed to guess something and said: “Ah, so they did build a new one in secret after all…”

“You knew the rebel government would build a new submersible after your… death?” Duncan asked with some surprise. “From what I know, the

Abyssal Trench Project was the root of that rebellion. They also used it as the reason to ‘execute’ you.”

“They would,” Ray Nora said with a small smile. “Because they are Frostholm people.”

For a moment, Duncan said nothing. He only watched this former Queen in silence.

She went on calmly: “Frostholm people never die quiet and meek. When the darkest hour comes, we will burn everything to live on. So when my Abyssal Trench Project went into a runaway state and the city-state fell into a crisis of survival, there had to be rebels who rose up, overthrew me, and made sure more people could live. And when they found the secret in the Deep Sea, they would surely build submersibles just as I did and try to solve this problem.

“They will improve the machines, slow down the plan, and learn from my extreme mistakes. They will try to do all of this in a gentler, less harmful way. And if they still fail, then new rebels will appear. The ones who come after will cut off the heads of those who could not do the job and then try yet another way… They will keep challenging the cold darkness in the Deep Sea.”

“It will go on until the last Frostholm person dies, or until this darkness clears.”

She lifted her head and looked into Duncan’s eyes with a calm, almost divine gaze. On his strange, frightening rough husk of a body, only those eyes still held a trace of human light.

“I only did not expect that the one who came down in a submersible would be… the legendary Captain Duncan, and clearly a Captain Duncan who has

gained his reason," she said softly. "It seems my successors are even more extreme than I was back then?"

"…They failed," Duncan said after a few seconds of silence, shaking his head slightly. "A disaster destroyed the city-state government. They did not restart the Abyssal Trench Project before things went into a runaway state. The only good news is that the disaster finally calmed, and we found that submersible as 'spoils of war' after everything settled."

Chapter 484: Spawn

The queen of Frostholm stayed silent for more than ten seconds. Her purple eyes were as clear and calm as gemstones, revealing nothing of her mood. The silence almost froze into suffocation before she finally nodded lightly and said: “Oh.”

Then she thought for a moment and asked: “So how is Frostholm now?”

Duncan looked into her eyes and spoke in a calm tone: “Tyrian is the new governor. The Sea Mist Fleet is fully taking over the city-state. The remaining Frostholm navy will be reorganized and rebuilt.”

Ray Nora showed a slight smile: “Ah, Tyrian. One of the possibilities… Fate is really hard to pin down. This result is not bad. What do you think?”

Duncan did not answer. He only went on calmly: “There is one more thing. The current head of the city-state Church follows my orders.”

Ray Nora finally showed a slightly surprised look. She tilted her head a little: “Hm? It sounds like… you are now the real master of Frostholm?”

“I have no interest in ruling a city-state—but you can think of it that way.”

“Now I am even more curious about what actually happened to make Frostholm’s situation turn out like this,” Ray Nora said, her expression growing serious. “I arranged many things, but your appearance was outside all my plans. You mentioned a disaster, but in my estimates, even if It entered a certain degree of runaway state, the situation should not have become as bad as you said…”

“A vast army of replicas from The Deep Sea invaded Frostholm. A mirror world city-state almost rose up into the Mortal Realm,” Duncan said in a low voice. “While you were trying to calm that tentacle in The Deep Sea, a group of cultists sensed the power leaking from It—and Frostholm’s ongoing mining of the Boiling Gold shaft, in a way, ‘helped’ those heretics.”

Duncan did not hide anything after that. He told the former queen of Frostholm everything that had happened there, including the changes brought by his own interference.

Ray Nora did not interrupt from start to finish. She listened quietly until Duncan’s words ended. Only then did she let out a long breath, a complicated smile appearing on her face: “Compared to the Elder Gods in The Deep Sea, it really is the mad humans who are more frightening.”

Then she paused and sighed in relief: “Still, in the worst path, we got an ending that is not too terrible—most people lived. That is enough.”

“Even if, in the end, the city-state became the property of a ‘Subspace shadow’ like me?” Duncan asked on purpose.

Ray Nora only smiled. Then she looked very seriously into Duncan’s eyes and said: “Then you must be the strongest guardian Frostholm has ever had.”

“Your attitude toward me is different from others,” Duncan said with some feeling. “Since I regained my humanity, I have met many people. Most of them were startled and jumpy. Few could stay calm when meeting me for the first time, let alone show such an optimistic attitude like you.”

Ray Nora shook her head: “This is not optimism. It is fact. You regained your humanity and helped Frostholm. That naturally makes you the strongest guardian of this city-state. I know most people feel instinctive fear

about this, but I have embraced fear for too long. I am used to looking through fear to see the true face of things."

"…Now it is my turn to ask questions." After hearing the queen of Frostholm's words, Duncan stayed silent for two or three seconds. Then he chose his words and spoke: "The replicant of the Abyssal Lord… when exactly did it invade the Mortal Realm? And will a similar 'invasion' happen again?"

"I am sorry. I cannot give a clear answer to the first question," Ray Nora said, a hint of apology on her face. "When I first noticed Its existence, It was already in The Deep Sea. And in the first few contacts, I only heard one voice… It said It was a faulty replicant. It said It needed to terminate its operation."

"Contact?" Duncan caught that word at once. "How did you 'contact' It at the beginning? And from what you are saying… this replicant told you about itself on Its own, and even asked you for help?"

Ray Nora nodded lightly: "I do not know if you have heard this, but I am a natural Psionic?"

"…I have indeed heard such rumors. They say you can know all things, past and present."

"Rumors exaggerate many things. I can neither foresee the future nor see through all things. But there is one thing they did not get wrong. A natural Psionic really can perform a Listening rite to hear 'voices' beyond the reach of ordinary people," Ray Nora said, as if lost in memories, thinking as she spoke slowly. "When I was very, very young, I often heard whispers from unknown sources, or saw strange and bizarre scenes in my sleep. Like most born Psionics, these terrible 'illnesses' were very dangerous. They even threatened the people taking care of me several times—

“Can you imagine it? You are caring for a two-or three-year-old child, and while the child is only dreaming in sleep, deadly shrieks suddenly fill the room, and swelling, writhing shadows appear… After my parents realized that the frequent horrors at home all came from the youngest child, they had no choice but to send me into the Cathedral. Like other born Psionics, I was put under the care of… ‘professionals.’

“I grew up in the deepest cellar of the great Cathedral until I was twelve. Fully armed Silent Monks and ascetics were my babysitters. Special shackles and a collar were my toys. A divinely blessed iron cage was my bed. The Gatekeeper came to check on me three times a week to make sure my mind still stayed on the side of humans. Only on my twelfth birthday, when my spirit and will had grown stronger and my awareness had become clear, did the Archbishop decide that I had stabilized on the ‘human’ side. Then they gave me divine blessing and Baptism, and announced to the outside world that I was a human.

“After that, I went through strict training to adapt to and control my gift, and to learn how to live in peace with my ‘nightmares.’ In four years, I gradually understood that my ‘dreams’ were actually a kind of resonance with the world. The whispers and shapes in my dreams came from beings that drifted outside the borders of the Mortal Realm and tried to make contact with our world. Once they were sure my mind could bear it, my Mentors taught me special methods to perform the Listening rite on those voices while keeping myself intact…

“And in that process, my ‘senses’ started to be drawn again and again toward The Deep Sea. I began to notice… Its existence.

“Or rather, It began to notice my existence.

“Every born Psionic has their own resonance tendency. Some tend to hear voices from history. Most of them become outstanding archaeologists and

hidden scholars. Some tend to hear the voices of the Four Gods. As long as they live to adulthood, they are almost destined to become the Saint. Others are less fortunate. They resonate with Subspace. Ninety-nine out of a hundred of them never leave the Cathedral cellar alive. The few who do become extremely rare Keepers of Secrets or hidden Saints, kept by the Church.

“And I formed a resonance with an Elder God that had awakened in The Deep Sea.”

Ray Nora stopped. Her gaze turned toward the far end of the room, toward that dark, chaotic, broken space. Under her gaze, the darkness stirred. The chaotic lights and shadows of Subspace faded away. Endless floating islands in The Deep Sea, and that silent “pillar,” showed themselves in the depths of the darkness.

That was her resonance. It was her nightmare, her fear, and her duty. It was both the beginning and the end.

“In fact, most of the time, I could not hear clearly what ‘It’ was saying at all. At first I thought it was because my own power was too weak, and I did not control Psychic Resonance well enough. But as time passed, I found that the reason was actually within this ‘Elder God’ itself.

“It was not whole. It was only a ‘replica’ copied by mistake from a greater being. It woke up in this dark Deep Sea knowing nothing. In Its broken and chaotic thoughts, only one idea filled everything—error. Immediate termination.

“It repeated that thought in my mind thousands, tens of thousands of times.”

Duncan finally spoke softly: “So you started the Abyssal Trench Project?”

“No. I first became the queen of Frostholm,” Ray Nora said calmly. “That took some work. Only by controlling the whole city-state could I have more

ways to investigate and confirm what I ‘heard.’ In that process, I discovered the anomaly deep in the Boiling Gold mine, and the link between all this and ‘The Deep Sea.’ The Abyssal Trench Project was the final result. I did a lot of preparation for that final result.”

Duncan did not speak for a moment. He rose slowly from his chair and walked to the far end of the room. He stared thoughtfully at the “view” of The Deep Sea that had appeared in the darkness, and at the tentacle, like a sky-piercing pillar, that ran through Frostholm’s “blueprint.”

After a long time, he turned his head slightly: “So It had no malice?”

“No malice and no kindness,” Ray Nora said. “In fact, It did not even have anything that could be called ‘intellect’—only a small fragment of broken, chaotic thought that ran through a simple judgment. It could not even understand Its own existence. So of course there was no such thing as an ‘attitude’ toward those tiny, fragile beings on the sea surface…

“It simply existed, in pain and in confusion, in this cold darkness. Yet such a simple ‘existence’ was enough to overturn our delicate and fragile so-called ‘civilized world.’”

Duncan muttered softly: “Existence itself is a threat…”

Ray Nora’s voice came from behind him a moment later: “Now I can answer your second question.

“Whether a similar ‘invasion’ will happen again—I think… it is possible. It is even certain.”

Duncan turned back at once: “Why?”

“Because it was not an ‘invasion’ at all. The Abyssal Lord did not ‘enter’ our Mortal Realm from Its own domain—It does not need to do that.

“Its ‘components’ naturally exist in the Mortal Realm. They are in every stretch of The Deep Sea, in every city-state, even in every human body. What happened in Frostholm’s Deep Sea was not an ‘invasion,’ but a… ‘awakening.’”

Ray Nora slowly spread her hands. A strange calm lay on her face. She fixed her gaze on Duncan’s eyes and spoke the greatest truth she had learned in her half century of nightmare sleep—

“Captain Duncan, in a certain sense, all of us, even the city-state under our feet, are the Elder Gods’ spawn.”

Chapter 485: Alice’s Secret

The room fell into silence.

This heavy silence lasted for an unknown length of time before Duncan suddenly broke it: “All beings in the world are Elder Gods’ spawn—even the most fanatical Annihilators have probably never spoken such a blasphemous conclusion.”

“Hearing the word ‘blasphemous’ from your mouth is truly unbelievable,” Ray Nora said, half smiling as her gaze met Duncan’s eyes. “Yet this really is the ultimate Truth I learned in that long nightmare. Just as in that scene you saw in The Deep Sea, the ‘Creation Doctrine’ preached by Annihilators is not entirely false. Perhaps they misunderstood it, but at least one thing is fact… Our world was created by the Elder Gods according to some grand ‘blueprint,’ and in that act of creation, Their flesh became the foundation of all things.”

Duncan stayed silent for a few seconds before speaking slowly, almost to himself: “The Abyssal Lord used Its own being as raw material and, following the ‘blueprint’ in The Deep Sea, shaped all things above the sea. Its ‘flesh’ naturally exists inside all things. Because of some ‘error,’ the ‘flesh’ that had already been shaped into worldly things became active. So the Elder Gods awoke from mortal flesh and from the ‘blueprints’ of city-states—that is the truth behind the Frostholm crisis?”

Ray Nora nodded slowly, her voice soft: “Copying and creating are the Abyssal Lord’s divine authority. It can evolve all things out of Its own being, so It took on the work of the Genesis Protocol. But clearly, after such

a long time, the original blueprint has started to fail. Or perhaps the ‘Creator’ that serves as the source went wrong. It began to wake from Its creations—waking again and again in the form of ‘faulty replicas.’ Frostholm was the first, but it will not be the last…”

Even with Duncan’s self-control, hearing these shocking and dreadful words made it hard to hold back the storm in his heart. The Elder Gods would gradually awaken from all living beings and even from all things in the world. In terms of sheer eerie horror, this was even more terrifying than that Black Sun hanging over the city-state of Pland!

“You learned all this in your nightmares, in communication with… ‘It’?” Duncan asked. He had to put in real effort to steady the wild surge in his thoughts. Forcing himself to keep calm, he turned his head toward that dark Deep Sea at the end of the room, looking at the huge “pillar” that stood quietly in the darkness.

“As an incomplete replica, It cannot tell me anything directly, but I can learn many things from It,” Ray Nora said. “I know what you want to say—human minds are weak. Even when we face the Truth, our limited senses and thoughts cannot fully and accurately grasp what we see. So I do not dare claim that what I say is one hundred percent ‘real.’ It is only what I grasped through my own senses and understanding, from an Elder God’s broken ‘thoughts’… for your reference only.”

Duncan did not answer at once. He fell into long thought. After an unknown time, he suddenly turned back: “‘Alice’—what exactly is she? Is she the body you planned to use for your resurrection?”

“‘Alice’?” Ray Nora frowned slightly when she heard the name. The confusion in her eyes did not look fake. “Who is Alice?”

“…So you do not know that name. I thought her awareness came from you,” Duncan said. He carefully checked the small changes in Ray Nora’s

expression before drawing back his searching gaze. “She is a doll who looks exactly like you. Many years ago, after you were… ‘executed,’ the people of Frostholm salvaged a container from the Frost Sea. Alice was sleeping inside it. She was once called Anomaly 099, but now she is a member of my crew.”

Ray Nora listened quietly to Duncan’s description. Her expression grew more and more thoughtful. After a long time, she suddenly showed a small smile: “Ah, so that is how it is…”

“So that is how it is?” Duncan caught that word at once. “What do you mean?”

“I have always been dreaming, all kinds of dreams. It is like drifting up and down on a sea shrouded in thick fog. Most of the time, I am wrapped in cold and darkness, falling asleep with those broken whispers. I can hardly tell whether the ‘me’ in the dream is the soul of a human or a dazed Elder God replicant in The Deep Sea. But sometimes… dry land appears in my dreams, and a swaying cabin, and some nervous strangers whispering to each other…”

As she spoke, she slowly lifted her head and looked at Duncan with a smile.

“In recent times, the second kind of dream has clearly appeared more often. The whispering strangers in the dream turned into many… strange but amusing items. They played and bickered with me. And there was always a trustworthy gaze watching from the edge of the dream… You care a great deal about that doll who calls herself ‘Alice,’ do you not?”

“There are not many people she can trust in this world. There are not many people I trust in this world either,” Duncan said. He looked very seriously at the ‘queen of Frostholm’ in front of him and did not relax just because of her gentle smile. “This runaway state sea has ‘copied’ many things—sunken

ships, drowned sailors. But the ‘executed queen’ is the most special. She is a doll with a self… Yet from your attitude, you did not know about this?”

Ray Nora seemed not to notice the stern seriousness in Duncan’s eyes. She only frowned a little, as if thinking hard. Slowly, a look of realization appeared. She closed her eyes as if feeling for something, then opened them again and looked at Duncan with a slightly odd expression: “That doll calls herself ‘Alice,’ does she?”

Duncan frowned: “Yes. Is there a problem?”

“Then… what if I say that doll is not actually my ‘replica’?” Ray Nora said seriously. “Or rather, not entirely my replica?”

“…What do you mean by that?”

“Is it possible…” Ray Nora paused, trying to keep serious, though her expression stayed awkward. “The Alice guillotine—the point is not ‘Alice.’ It is ‘guillotine’…”

“…?” Duncan stared.

“I do not really want to recall this,” Ray Nora said as she reached up and rubbed the back of her neck with a strange look on her face. “Do you know that when the rebels executed me, they used a device called the ‘Alice guillotine’…”

A light finally flashed through Duncan’s mind. He understood what the ‘queen of Frostholm’ meant.

But he almost wished he did not.

“You mean you suspect ‘Alice’ was actually copied by this runaway state sea from that ‘guillotine,’ not from your body…”

Duncan spoke without thinking, but stopped halfway, muttering to himself in confusion: “But that cannot be right. She looks exactly like you…”

“Faulty copying, Captain,” Ray Nora said. She clearly already had an answer. She shook her head and looked toward the dark Deep Sea at the end of the room. “A damaged, faulty Elder God replicant caused this runaway state sea. In such a runaway state sea, faulty copying is the norm. When a decapitated queen and a guillotine sank into The Deep Sea together, and because of my earlier arrangements fell exactly into the ‘perception’ range of the Elder God’s tentacle, it may have triggered some… strange changes. Mixing and recombining, copying and making whole, and a little… processing from the mystic field.”

She stopped there and looked at the Elder God’s tentacle standing in the darkness, her gaze complicated.

“Clearly, It could not tell the difference…”

The room fell into silence again.

But this silence was completely different from before.

After this suffocating quiet lasted for several minutes, Duncan finally broke it with a sigh: “So in a sense, It was raising a placenta…”

Ray Nora opened her mouth. After a few seconds of stunned silence, she managed: “An unprecedented but perfectly fitting metaphor. As expected of you…”

Duncan let out a helpless sigh. What else could he say? In this dark, boundless Deep Sea, the way things developed had already gone beyond everyone’s expectations. The Elder Gods’ madness and unspeakable nature showed themselves in every detail. To use a less fitting metaphor—in choosing between saving the mother or the child, the Elder Gods chose to save the placenta…

But at least he had understood one thing—

Why did that silly doll think her name was “Alice”?

Because she really was the Alice guillotine.

Since coming to this world, Duncan had seen more strange and twisted things than he could count. Yet even among all those, this was definitely the most twisted of all.

“Look on the bright side. At least there is one thing you do not need to worry about,” Ray Nora said, noticing Duncan’s dark mood and trying to comfort him. “Alice is not a body I prepared for my resurrection. In fact, from the very beginning, I never planned any so-called ‘resurrection.’”

Listening to the queen of Frostholm’s words, Duncan turned to look at her again. He had to work hard to adjust his mood, forcing away the lingering sense of wrongness in his heart and pulling the topic back on track: “Then… what about that key you mentioned at the start? What about the keyhole on Alice’s back? Were none of those your arrangements?”

“I do not know what ‘keyhole’ you are talking about. But if the key you mean is a brass winding key, then yes, I did leave it to the city’s governor. It is also the item I just mentioned that is needed to enter this room in the normal way,” Ray Nora said openly. Then she changed the subject: “But I am not the key’s creator, nor its first owner.”

Duncan froze for a moment. His eyes changed: “…You were not the key’s first owner? Then where did you get it?”

“It was a gift from a friend,” Ray Nora said calmly. “An elderly man who was knowledgeable and kind.”

Chapter 486: Ray Nora’s “Friend”

The brass key that Ray Nora had left behind was actually a gift from a friend. This completely took Duncan by surprise.

It also stirred his curiosity even more.

Who exactly had made that key, and for what purpose? What was the true nature of that key? And what was the vision he had seen after touching it—the vessel crashing to the ground and breaking apart in an explosion?

He was desperate to know the answers. Luckily, the Frostholm Queen did not hide what she knew and spoke frankly:

“I met that friend not long after I left the great Cathedral. At the time I was planning how to take power, often meeting all kinds of people and taking part in public affairs. That old man showed up at a fundraising gathering…

“He was not on the guest list, yet he slipped past all the guards and all the eyes watching the place with ease. I thought he was a professor from the university, because he wore a scholar’s robe and had a refined, proper manner. I did not know he had snuck in, so I chatted with him. His vast knowledge was astonishing… until the bodyguards at the gathering finally realized what was going on and threw him out.

“But after that, the old man began to appear in my sight again and again. Sometimes it was at upper-class parties, sometimes at private dinners hosted by friends. He would appear whenever everyone’s eyes were elsewhere, then calmly come up to talk with me. He discussed history, mathematics, and occult studies with me, and always slipped away before

anyone else could notice. Aside from that first time, when the bodyguards found him, he always managed to hide himself from everyone's eyes.

"Isn't it unbelievable? A friend only I knew about, a learned adviser… an 'air friend'.

"I never told anyone about him. At first, I was afraid of worrying the Church. The bishops would suspect my Psionic gift had entered a runaway state and would lock me back in the cellar. I knew my power had not gone out of control and I did not fear being chained up again, but I felt my time was precious. I could not waste it in a cage. Later, when I began to gain control of the city-state's power, I had even more reason to hide the existence of this 'secret adviser'.

"This went on for about three years. I became close friends with this mysterious old man despite our age difference. Just when I thought he would continue to serve as my 'special staff member' until my coronation, he suddenly appeared before dawn one day and said goodbye.

"This was what he said: 'The Window Interval is over. This is the last time we will meet.'

"Then he handed me a brass key and told me that the key was a twisted aggregate, a key that could create links in time and space. It could also carry knowledge and memories. One day in the future, it would surely play its part…

"After he told me many things about the key, my 'air friend' simply turned around and walked toward the first beam of light from the rising dawn. The moment the Sun rose over the horizon, he vanished. That was the last time I saw him."

Duncan listened to Ray Nora's story in astonishment. Countless thoughts rose in his mind, and they all quickly pointed to one word. As soon as the

Frostholm Queen finished speaking, he spoke at once: “Wait. From your description, that person sounds exactly like a…”

“Yes, a Ender, Captain Duncan,” Ray Nora said with a smile. “I guessed it after our first few meetings. In all those years of training in the Cathedral I read more books than I can count. Of course I knew what a Ender was.”

“You became friends with a Ender, and he even…” Duncan spoke with a frown, but halfway through he sensed something wrong. “Wait, no. He doesn’t sound like a normal Ender…”

“That’s right, just as you said,” Ray Nora answered. “In ‘nature’ he was very similar, but his state was nothing like those mad cultists. His mind was keen, his reason was clear, and his manner was gentle and friendly. The only thing he had in common with the other Enders was his ‘nonlinear way of appearing and disappearing’.”

“Normal Enders cannot think or speak calmly. The tearing of the timelines has already shattered their perception, and their worship of Subspace has destroyed their reason,” Duncan said quickly. “But the one you knew was the opposite…”

He suddenly stopped.

Because in that instant, he remembered something else. It was something related to “himself”.

Tyrian had once mentioned, while talking with Vanna and Valentine, that a century ago, just before “Duncan Abnomar” set sail on his final voyage, several mysterious Visitors had come aboard the Vanished. They wore robes like those of ascetic monks, appeared on the ship without warning, and talked all night with the Duncan of that time. Then, when the Sun rose the next day, they vanished as mysteriously as they had come…

Tyrian had always believed that the visit of those mysterious Visitors was the direct reason the Vanished sailed toward the “border” on that last voyage.

And those mysterious Visitors, from the description, had been a group of clear-minded, gentle, and friendly “Enders”!

The body Duncan was using now could not show complex expressions, but his brief silence and the change in his eyes did not escape the sharp gaze of the Frostholm Queen. Ray Nora reacted at once: “Did something come to mind?”

Duncan lifted his head. He did not speak for a moment. He simply gazed quietly into her eyes with his gaze.

The “friend” Ray Nora knew was not the only one. Among the Enders, a group most people saw as cruel and insane cultists, there really were some individuals who still had reason. Their goals were unknown. They moved along the timelines, using a kind of contact period called the “Window Interval” to keep meddling in the affairs of the mortal world.

Countless thoughts rose and flashed through his mind. At last Duncan broke the silence: “They once visited the Vanished as well.”

For the first time, Ray Nora’s eyes opened wide at once.

It seemed she had not completely lost the ability to feel surprise, as she had claimed at the start.

“You have met clear-minded Enders too?” Ray Nora said quickly. “What did they tell you? They were…”

“Sadly, I no longer remember,” Duncan cut off her hurried questions. “That part of my memory vanished with Subspace’s corruption. I only learned from other sources that I once had dealings with them.”

An undisguised look of regret appeared on Ray Nora's face.

Duncan quickly gathered his thoughts and pulled the topic back on track: "After you realized he was a special kind of Ender, did you ever talk with him about his real identity? Did you ask about his purpose?"

"Of course I asked. But do you think he would give me an answer?" Ray Nora sighed helplessly. "We got along very well. He was both a teacher and a friend to me, and he was happy to answer most of my questions. But whenever I tried to steer the topic toward his 'identity', he always brushed it aside with one line:

"'It is not time yet. Do not reach for what lies beyond the boundary too early.'"

"'Do not reach for what lies beyond the boundary too early…'" Duncan repeated the words in a low voice. He frowned slightly. "You still managed to become friends with such a suspicious person under those conditions. One could say you have a… very generous heart."

"I needed help. Most things in this world that can be called 'power' are dangerous," Ray Nora said calmly. "Compared to the 'dreams' I have dealt with since childhood, a Ender was actually far too gentle and harmless."

Duncan said nothing more. He stood up again and slowly walked to the darkness at the far end of the room.

"One last thing. What plans do you have… for your own future?"

Ray Nora frowned slightly: "My future?"

"Do you have to stay in this room called the 'Drifting Place' forever?" Duncan asked. He lifted his chin and pointed at the huge "tentacle" in the darkness of the Deep Sea. "Do you have to stay here forever, using dreams to hold down this 'flawed replicant'?"

“Do you have another way?”

“Maybe, but I am not sure,” Duncan said. “If I completely destroy this flawed replicant, what will happen?”

“Freedom…” Ray Nora fell silent for a few seconds, then nodded slowly and solemnly. “Both I and It will be freed.”

“And after that?”

“I do not know,” Ray Nora said, shaking her head. “That is already beyond my understanding. I have never even imagined what it would be like if this long nightmare finally ended. Maybe this ‘Drifting Place’ will lose this connection point and link to some other place. Maybe I will lose my connection with the Mortal Realm, no longer be troubled by nightmares, and become an idle wandering spirit, waiting for the day someone opens this room again.”

“That does not sound like a very good ending,” Duncan said, his tone growing heavier. “Eternal exile is not much better than sinking into a nightmare.”

“In fact, it is even worse, because I do not control this room,” Ray Nora replied. “Compared with reconnecting to some ‘connection point’ in the Mortal Realm, it is more likely that, while drifting in a runaway state, it will sink to the Subspace side.”

Duncan fell silent again and did not speak for a long time.

After a moment, Ray Nora broke the silence on her own: “Even so, I still advise you to do it. If you really can, then end all this while I still have time.”

Duncan gazed into the Frostholm Queen’s eyes with his gaze: “Are you sure? Even if it means you will suffer eternal exile?”

“Being trapped in a nightmare forever is also a kind of eternal exile,” Ray Nora said with a smile. “If I can be freed like this, it will at least solve the long-term threat Frostholm faces. At least for quite a long time, my city-state and my people will be safe.”

Chapter 487: Setting Fire to the Deep Sea

Ray Nora's tone was calm and detached, as if many years ago she had already planned every scene of her own End. Whether it was being trapped in a nightmare forever or suffering eternal exile, it was just one of the steps that had always been part of her planned future.

Just as Duncan had thought, the Frostholm Queen had never prepared for her own "resurrection". Returning to the Mortal Realm had never been part of her plan from the very beginning.

Yet this ready, fearless attitude made Duncan feel strange.

"Are you really willing to give everything for Frostholm? Even more than your life?" He turned his head and looked into Ray Nora's eyes with curiosity. "You spent more than ten years living in a cage beneath the Cathedral. You were not treated as a human being until you were twelve. You were watched, chained, and tested. Every thought you had, every sentence you muttered in your sleep, was taken as a possible sign of betraying humans and was analyzed again and again. You did everything you could, yet in the end you were still sent to the guillotine as the 'mad Queen'… I do not want to judge anyone from a dark point of view, but at least from a logical angle, I am very surprised by your choice."

Ray Nora fell silent. She leaned against her bed and looked up at the gauze hanging above. Her thoughts seemed to drift very far away. After a long

time, she suddenly smiled and shook her head: “Yes… why am I doing this…”

She turned her head and gazed quietly into Duncan’s eyes with her gaze.

“Do you know, they could have burned me to death,” she said. “A long, long time ago, on the day I first woke from a nightmare, before I learned to say ‘Dad’ and ‘Mother’, before I knew I was a human… Captain, maybe the way I told my story made you misunderstand something. You think I should hate that cold city, but in fact it was that city that did everything it could to keep me alive.

“On a wider scale, it is our delicate yet fragile civilized world that is doing its best to let everyone live. That includes natural-born Psionics like me. Even if they had to use chains, iron cages, and a dungeon to hold me there for ten years, they never expected me to die in that cold place. They hoped I would come back as a human.

“I have never hated anyone, Captain. They did not treat me cruelly, because this world is cruel to everyone. Everyone is only doing the best they can.”

The former Frostholm Queen let out a soft sigh, then slowly rose and stepped down from her bed that was like a cage. Compared with the ten years she had spent in the Cathedral’s cellar, perhaps the only difference was that this bed did not have a ring of bars around it.

She walked slowly to the far end of the room and stood beside Duncan, looking out at the chaotic darkness of the Deep Sea.

“My parents and the people in the Cathedral did their best to keep me alive,” she said. “My supporters and I did our best to keep the city-state safe. Governor Winston and all his predecessors did their best to finish the work I could not. But very often, doing our best does not mean we will succeed. Failure naturally has its price.”

She slowly raised her arm and pointed at the huge tentacle in the darkness.

“Even the Elder Gods have to face failure, do they not?”

“If your theory is correct, new flawed replicants will appear sooner or later, waking from the creations of the mortal world,” Duncan said after thinking for a moment. “Destroying the flawed replicant here cannot fix the root of the whole world.”

“Other people will ‘do their best’,” Ray Nora said calmly, turning to look at Duncan. “What about you? Will you act?”

Duncan stayed silent for a while. Then he spoke softly: “I will do my best.”

“That is enough,” Ray Nora said with a smile. “Then do it. I have slept for too long. It is time to wake from this nightmare… and it is time to free It as well.”

There was a hint of urgency in her voice, as if she could hardly wait.

Duncan hesitated for a long time, then finally nodded in silence.

In the next second, a cluster of ghostly green flame suddenly appeared beside him. The fire spun and swelled, slowly turning into a swirling doorway.

He walked toward the great door, and at that moment Ray Nora’s expression suddenly changed a little.

She stared at the rising green flames, as if looking at a distant, hazy memory. Then she suddenly turned her head and looked at Duncan, who was about to step through the door: “It was you?!”

Duncan stopped. After a brief moment of confusion, he finally realized why the Frostholm Queen was reacting like this.

“I suppose this does not count as corruption of history,” he said, keeping his posture as if he were about to step through the door and turning his head slightly. “What do you think?”

“So that is how it is… so that is how it is…” Ray Nora murmured. Expressions flashed quickly across her face, as if many worries from years ago had suddenly become clear. Then a faint light seemed to rise in her eyes. For the first time, she showed a bright, heartfelt smile. She raised her head to look at Duncan and waved, just as she had once waved goodbye to an old friend many years ago. “Go on. Do what you must. I think… we are making the right choice.”

Duncan gave the Frostholm Queen one last, deep look. He did not say anything more. He stepped forward and walked into the spinning door of flame.

Ray Nora stood there quietly, watching his figure disappear from the room.

It was just like many years ago, when that gentle, learned old man had vanished into the morning light.

She slowly drew back her gaze and turned around. She stood at the broken edge of the room, looking at the Elder Gods’ tentacle that was now in a state of stillness. She looked at her nightmare of the past half century, and at all the fate and duty bound to it.

Thin strands of eerie green flame rose from the dark abyss of the sea beyond. At first they were as small as fireflies, but in an instant they spread quickly, growing larger and stronger, and began to spread and burn along the whole “pillar”.

A slight tremor appeared under her feet and grew stronger with each passing moment.

The mansion began to shake. The power that supported this dream was fading. The “connection point” between the Drifting Place and the outside world was breaking apart and vanishing. The darkness outside the room suddenly seemed to surge. Countless ripples and shifting lights spread wildly and then drew back into the dark again. In that unstable glow, the Elder Gods’ tentacle began to change. It seemed to bend. Vague structures grew from its tip, stretching and crossing the shifting border between real and unreal, bending down toward this shattered room.

Ray Nora only stood quietly before this terrifying sight. She watched the phantom, newborn smaller tendril bend and stretch toward her. She watched it finally reach the invisible boundary, where its black “flesh” pressed against the unseen barrier and spread out.

Ray Nora slowly stretched out her hand and placed her palm on that shifting surface of flesh. Through the dream’s barrier, she felt everything It was sending to her—confusion, tension, unease, and a hint of regret.

“Yes… I know. You never wanted to appear in this world… It will be over soon. Treat it as a dream. You will go back to where you should be…

“I will leave too, soon. When the anchor cable breaks, that will be the moment of departure… I might go very far away, or I might never have another destination. Even if my calculations are right, it will probably be a journey so long it is hard to imagine… So if there is any scenery to see, I will enjoy it.”

The soundless exchange went on in the dream. In these last moments before waking, Ray Nora suddenly felt a bit sentimental.

“We have been together for so long, and I have never asked your name,” she said, gazing with her gaze at the tentacle beyond the dream’s border and feeling the confused, broken messages It sent. Most of those messages could not even be called complete ‘thoughts’. They were more like scraps

of inspiration from a damaged soul struggling to think. But in half a century together, she had grown used to ‘talking’ with this broken will. “Of course, I know the title Abyssal Lord, and I know you have other titles as well… but those are not your name…

“Do you have a name? Whether it is yours or your ‘true body’s’… It is nothing. I just suddenly felt curious.”

In the sea of chaotic noise and murmurs, one thought suddenly came through very clearly.

Ray Nora listened in silence, performing the Listening rite just as she had as a child, when she had crouched among cold bars and chains, listening to the vague whispers from the depths of the tide. A name seemed to rise in her mind as if she were half awake and half asleep.

A faint smile slowly appeared on her lips: “LH-01… what a strange name… Navigator One? Was that your original name?

“All right, I will remember it. It was a pleasure to meet you, Navigator One. Then… farewell, and good morning.”

A roaring wave of flame surged from the depths of the darkness like a tsunami and reached this place. In the blink of an eye it swallowed the tentacle that was touching the Drifting Place. In the burning flames, the Elder Gods’ flawed replicant returned to dust and ashes.

The blazing flames even burned through the dream’s barrier for a brief moment. At Ray Nora’s feet, in the air around her, and at the edges of the room, strange yet brilliant sparks bloomed like flowers.

Ray Nora watched the leaping spirit form flames with curiosity and reached out to touch their edges.

The warm fire faded at her fingertips.

In the dark, icy Deep Sea, the suddenly rising ghostly flames lit up the whole sea like a coronal eruption. They lit the dark floating island drifting in the Deep Sea and shone on the human-shaped empty shells that floated in the black water like a swarm of bees.

Duncan floated quietly at the edge of the dark floating island, watching the spirit form blaze he had lit burn fiercely. Its power was so great that even he, the one who had started the fire, felt a deep sense of shock.

Chapter 488: Homeward Voyage

The fire spread faster and fiercer than Duncan had imagined.

He had only lit a small flame at the edge of that gigantic “pillar” and had been ready to wait for it to spread slowly. He had not expected that tiny spark to instantly swell into a towering blaze that lit up The Deep Sea. Beneath the weight of hundreds of millions of tons of seawater, the roaring fire looked even more uncanny than usual.

supernatural things were the best fuel for spirit form flames, and the Elder Gods’ tentacles naturally counted as “supernatural”. Even so, the fire still burned far too fiercely and too fast.

It was as if some power was acting as a catalyst, strengthening the spirit flame.

Was it the special environment of The Deep Sea itself? Or was that Elder God tentacle actively “cooperating”?

Duncan frowned a little and felt the enormous stream of information the flames were sending to him. The information was broken and scattered, mixed with masses of twisted noise and fragments of light and shadow. It seemed to be the uncontrolled spillover from the tentacle’s collapse.

To an ordinary person, even a single whisper from those things could have been enough to bring madness. Duncan only found them trivial and chaotic. He tried hard to pick useful information out of the jumbled noise, and right before all the noise faded, he finally “heard” a few “voices” he could understand.

In the water, he suddenly opened his eyes wide, a little stunned, and stared at the Elder God tentacle that was rapidly collapsing and disintegrating in the spirit flame.

“LH-01? Navigator One?!”

In the void, it was as if a roar came from The Deep Sea. The flawed replicant of the Elder God finally broke apart completely. All the noise vanished, and no voice answered Duncan’s sudden question. In the silence that followed, a silence that felt filled with endless emptiness, only one vague thought drifted quietly through his mind like a phantom in the mist—

“Thank you, bearer of the Flame Usurper.”

Duncan blinked. His mind surged with tangled thoughts and countless startling guesses and associations. He did not know how long passed. Just as he began to consider whether to keep exploring this place, whether to keep diving deeper, a flicker of fire suddenly appeared at the edge of his vision.

He snapped his head around and saw that the AI, which had been flitting around him, suddenly began to flicker violently, like a projection with a bad connection. The fiery glow over the whole pigeon turned dim and bright by turns. It beat its wings rapidly and let out a sharp, broken cry: “Your… signal quality is poor, please check… your hardware connec… remote server… wait…”

Duncan’s eyes tightened at once. He waved his hand and teleported the AI back. In the next second, as the AI returned to the Vanished, he noticed that the “temporary body” he was using was rapidly falling apart.

In the blink of an eye, cracks of all sizes spread over the whole of this rough-husk-like body. The eerie green flame that leaped within the cracks was rapidly dissipating.

In the surrounding seawater, the “human shapes” drifting everywhere also began to show the same signs of collapse. Countless human husks quickly turned into black fragments and sank toward that pitch-black floating island of Frostholm in The Deep Sea.

The flawed replicant of the Elder God had been burned away by the blaze, and the human Rough Husks that surrounded the floating island in The Deep Sea collapsed with it. Aside from the island itself, which might be the original Blueprint, everything in this part of The Deep Sea was quickly breaking down and dispersing, returning to… the “normal state of the original design”.

Duncan quickly worked out the chain of cause and effect behind these changes. In the next second, he felt his consciousness forcibly pop out of this body that could no longer be sustained.

Right before his senses cut off, only one thought remained in his mind—

What a pity about this body that suited The Deep Sea. He had thought he could use it for a long time, but it turned out to be another one?time shell…

The low rumble of the ballast tank pumping water out echoed inside the submersible. With a slight tremor, the whole machine began to rise faster.

At the controls, Duncan let out a regretful sigh, mourning the loss of yet another “temporary body” while he checked the machine’s status.

The Deep Sea turbulence caused by the collapse of that giant “pillar” had slammed into the slowly ascending submersible, but luckily it had not caused any damage.

Agatha’s voice, full of shock, came from beside him: “Just now… what was that?!”

She lifted a hand and pointed out the porthole, toward the stretch of dark Deep Sea that was quickly returning to gloom. Yet in the boundless

darkness, traces of green radiance still flared now and then. Vast streams of ghostly green light looked as if they were burning furiously along some enormous wreck, or as if a chain of explosions were going off in that darkness.

Outside the submersible, chaotic currents churned everywhere. The noise of the machinery and the dull bangs that thudded from the hull from time to time were enough to rattle the nerves.

There was no doubt that something huge had just happened below.

"…I found the source of Frostholm's crisis. At the center of that floating island in The Deep Sea that seems to be a 'Creation Blueprint', there was a gigantic Elder God tentacle. It was a flawed replicant of the Abyssal Lord, and its presence affected this entire sea area," Duncan said as he turned his head slightly and glanced at Agatha, who was clearly waiting for an explanation. "For the past fifty years, the soul of the Frostholm Queen has been soothing that flawed replicant. She has held on for far too long."

Agatha slowly opened her mouth wide.

She had not expected that Captain Duncan could simply go down in an avatar form to take a look and come back with news this shocking!

She stared in stunned silence for a long time before she finally snapped out of it and spoke without thinking: "Then… what then? What happened after that?"

"I burned it," Duncan said, keeping it short.

Agatha did not react at first: "…You burned it?"

"I burned it," Duncan repeated, and raised his hand to point out of the porthole. "Didn't you see? I set it on fire."

“No, it’s not that I didn’t understand you. I understand… no, I don’t understand, I really don’t understand,” Agatha actually became a little incoherent. Even when she had faced hundreds of cultists in that eerie and evil sacrificial ground, she had never felt this at a loss, but in front of Captain Duncan, who never seemed to follow any normal rules, her sanity always felt a bit lacking. “You just… burned it? An Elder God… even if it was only a flawed replicant of an Elder God… you just burned it?”

Of course Duncan had known Agatha would react like this, but he truly had no idea how to explain the endless details. After wrestling with it for a long while, he could only shrug helplessly: “Honestly, I was surprised too. It was more flammable than I expected.”

Agatha: “…”

After a brief silence, this Miss Gatekeeper finally managed to get her thoughts back on track: “Then… what about the Frostholm Queen’s soul? Did you ‘burn’ it along with everything else?”

“She gained her freedom, but I don’t know where she will go—maybe we will meet again,” Duncan said, each word completely honest. “I talked with her about many things, including her experiences while she was alive, the secrets in The Deep Sea, and some… truths about our world. Most of it is very subversive.”

“Very subversive?” Agatha still seemed not quite recovered from the earlier shock of ‘I burned it’. Her thoughts were clearly a step slow. She listened to Duncan and only spoke on reflex: “What kind of subversive?”

“The kind where, before you listen, you need to burn incense, receive a benediction, and write a will. And after you listen, you need Quarantine Observation and a Sanity Check,” Duncan turned his head and glanced at her. “I will tell you, once we are back on safe land and I am sure you are ready.”

Even as a Gatekeeper who had passed through many trials and had an extremely tough mind, Agatha still felt her nerves tighten at his words without thinking.

For this “captain” who could even return from Subspace to speak in such a solemn and serious tone… just what secrets had he learned in that cold, boundless darkness?

At the same time, back on the Vanished, Duncan had already returned from that “studio apartment” sealed in thick fog and come back to his captain’s cabin.

On the edge of the enchanted sea chart table, the dark Goathead creaked as it turned its neck. Its obsidian inlaid eyes fell on the captain.

“Name?” it asked in a stiff, formal tone.

“Duncan Abnomar.” Duncan waved a hand, sat down at the table, then looked up at Goathead again: “Was I gone for too long?”

“You were too far away,” Goathead seemed to breathe a sigh of relief, and its tone immediately relaxed. “I felt a strand of your will go to a very, very distant place, so far that even the Vanished could barely sense it. Please don’t be angry, I was only worried about your safety. After all, such a big ship is still counting on our wise captain to lead it…”

“That’s enough. I know all about your loyalty, reliability, diligence, and thoughtfulness. Don’t worry, it was only a distant but brief trip. It didn’t have any real effect—what is Alice doing?”

“Miss Alice?” Goathead paused for a moment, then spoke again: “She was resting in her cabin just now… ah, she is coming toward the captain’s cabin. She seems to be in a hurry.”

No sooner had Goathead finished speaking than hurried footsteps sounded from the deck outside the door, and Alice’s familiar presence appeared

outside.

Just as a knock was about to sound, Duncan spoke first: “Come in.”

The next second, two knocks still came, and then the doll belatedly let out an “oh” outside, opened the door, and walked into the room.

“Captain! Captain, Captain!” As soon as she came in, Alice hurried over to Duncan. Before he could say anything, she rattled off: “Something happened! I just had a dream! I just had a dream!”

Duncan had originally had many things he wanted to say to Alice, but he had not expected her to be even more flustered than he was. He frowned: “You had a dream? What did you dream of?”

“I don’t really remember the details!” Alice said with full confidence. “I just felt like, in the dream, I was kind of… impressive? Like that feeling you talked about before… like I’d grown a brain?”

Chapter 489: Turning the key

Duncan quietly looked at Alice, and Alice looked back at Duncan with the same confident expression.

After a moment, Duncan rubbed his brow first and felt a strange emotion rise in his heart, a sense of wrongness that would not go away.

It was clearly the same face. How could it show such a completely different air…

“Captain,” Alice blinked curiously when she saw Duncan’s reaction and leaned closer to ask: “Why aren’t you saying anything? Did I say something wrong?”

“…No, it’s not your fault.” Duncan shook his head, pulling himself out of his messy thoughts. Then he suddenly lifted his gaze and looked at the doll in front of him with a solemn, serious expression: “Alice, have you ever been curious about the connection between you and the Frostholm Queen?”

Alice froze for a moment, raised a hand to scratch her head, and seemed to think quite seriously before she answered, not very sure: “I… have been curious, but then I thought about it, and it didn’t seem like something very important, so I stopped thinking about it.”

Duncan was a little surprised: “Not very important?”

“The Frostholm Queen is the Frostholm Queen, and I am me. No matter how great that queen is, that’s her business, and I don’t understand it anyway,” Alice said with a very serious face. “I have things I’m good at,

and I really like my days now. That’s good enough. And I heard Mr. Morris say that in this world everyone might find another person who looks almost exactly like them, so I’ll just think of the Frostholm Queen as the person who looks exactly like me—though I’m actually a doll…”

Duncan quietly listened to the doll’s words and watched the natural, content light in her eyes when she talked about her days now. Something was suddenly moved in his heart.

Maybe… she really was only a special, flawed replica made by an Elder God in The Deep Sea. Maybe she really was only the result of Ray Nora falling into The Deep Sea and fusing strangely with that Guillotine. Or maybe even more secrets were hidden in her, secrets that even Ray Nora could not have imagined… But just as Alice herself had said, that was not very important.

She was not clever, yet she was very happy. There were many things she could not understand, but she had never felt nervous or afraid because of these overly complicated matters. She had been born and lived in a world full of strangeness, yet this strange world was, to her, the most ordinary kind of “normal”. In this world, full of novelty and unknowns in her eyes, she explored, she felt curious, she looked forward to everything, including tomorrow, just like…

a child who opened their eyes under the sunlight.

The living beings of the mortal world were beyond counting, yet even the bravest warrior, the most learned sage, and the most devout believer could not look at this world from a viewpoint like Alice’s.

Duncan suddenly had a feeling. In this eerie world where everyone carried fear in their hearts and all things were twisting out of shape, Alice, this “doll”, seemed more like a “human” than anyone.

Just like the ordinary humans he had seen in that other world, in that world without Anomalies and Visions, without Gods and weirdness, who walked calmly under the sunlight.

“Captain?” Alice’s curious voice sounded again: “Why are you spacing out again?”

“It’s nothing,” Duncan shook his head. “I just suddenly felt that… you actually have a lot of wisdom.”

When Alice heard the captain praise her, she froze for a moment, and then a happy look slowly spread over her face: “Hehe…”

She did not know why the captain suddenly said she had “wisdom”, and she had never even thought that she might have any wisdom, but if the captain praised her like this, then it was certainly something to be happy about.

After praising her, Duncan fell silent for a brief moment, thinking. Then he slowly reached his hand to his side. A cold touch came to his fingertips. It was the brass key.

In The Deep Sea, the submersible was still slowly rising, and there was still some time before “recovery”.

Ray Nora, the Frostholm Queen, had given him a great deal of information, but much of it was still incomplete or vague and needed him to verify it himself.

The brass key… A rational Ender had placed it in Ray Nora’s hands, yet even with her abilities, she had never managed to understand the true “essence” of this key. At the same time, on Alice, this flawed replicant who seemed to have been born purely by “coincidence”, a matching Keyhole had appeared… Was it still coincidence at this point?

Had that Ender foreseen all of this today? Or, when that Elder God tentacle sleeping in The Deep Sea created “Alice”, had it searched through Ray

Nora’s memories and left the “Keyhole” in Alice’s body?

Maybe… it was time to try.

“Alice,” Duncan suddenly raised his head and looked at the doll in front of him with a solemn face: “Come with me.”

“Ah?” Alice was startled for a moment, but she quickly reacted, stood up, and followed: “Oh, okay!”

“Hold the helm.” Duncan rose from behind the enchanted sea chart table, gave Goathead a brief instruction, then took a light breath and turned toward the captain’s quarters.

Not knowing what was going on, Alice followed behind Duncan and walked through the bedroom door with him. At his instruction, she turned back to close the door, then turned again and looked at Duncan curiously.

“Captain? What are we doing next?”

Duncan silently held the key in his hand and looked at the doll: “I want to test this key.”

When Alice heard this, she was a little surprised: “Ah? Didn’t you say this key might be dangerous? That the Frostholm Queen’s soul might be living inside it or something…”

“The hidden danger has been cleared,” Duncan said calmly. “I just dealt with it myself.”

“Oh!” Alice answered at once. Then she turned around and felt for the zipper on the back of her clothes without a bit of hesitation: “Then I’ll open my clothes first…”

“You only need to expose the Keyhole,” Duncan said. Even after spending so long with this solid?headed doll, he still felt a bit embarrassed by her

complete lack of hesitation. He reminded her without thinking, then added with some surprise: “You’re not afraid?”

“You said there’s no hidden danger anymore, Captain,” Alice said, turning her head. “And you’re the one who will wind me up yourself. If something goes wrong, you’ll definitely protect me, right?”

“…Yes, I will protect you.” After a brief two or three seconds of silence, Duncan slowly nodded. Then he raised his hand and pointed to a round stool beside the bed: “Sit here—I’m not sure what will happen after I wind you, so you’d better not stand.”

“Oh!” Alice agreed and obediently came over to sit on the round stool, turning her back to Duncan.

The doll’s clothes were already open at the back.

Duncan finally saw what the “Keyhole” looked like. It was set right in the center of Alice’s back, which was as smooth as white porcelain. The Keyhole was embedded there abruptly, surrounded by a ring of fine, ornate patterns with a texture like gilding.

Duncan lowered his head and glanced at the brass key in his hand.

…The size and shape really did match perfectly.

A strange feeling rose in his heart, mixed with a bit of tension. Duncan took a light breath, controlled that odd emotion, and slowly brought the key close to the round hole.

“Alice.”

“Mm?”

“Don’t be afraid.”

“Okay!”

The winding key slid into the Keyhole without the slightest resistance. Right after that, a clear “click” sounded beside Duncan’s ear, as if it rang directly in his mind.

Some mechanism had been triggered—but it was not an ordinary clockwork.

A faint force came from his fingertips, and Duncan instantly realized that the winding key was turning by itself. It slowly turned to a horizontal position, and then another “click” came.

In the next second, everything before his eyes began to change sharply.

Light and shadow collapsed and reformed. His senses went through a shift and reset. There was that familiar slight dizziness again, that feeling of “transfer” like walking in the Spirit Realm—

Before he had time to sigh in his heart: [Here we go again], everything around Duncan had already settled down.

He now stood inside a grand mansion that was old and splendid, yet also gloomy and eerie.

The classical and solemn hall was wide and empty. Tall pillars lined both sides of the hall, holding up the gloomy roof above that was like a mass of gathered dark clouds. Long, narrow windows were set into the walls, which were covered with patterns and reliefs. Outside the windows, black thorns seemed to crawl across the surface, and muddled lights and shadows swirled beyond the thorny tangle.

And in this grim, uncanny mansion, human voices sounded now and then—whispering, broken bits of talk and laughter, footsteps on the floor, and even… strange, blurred music, as if a ball were being held somewhere.

Duncan frowned slightly and let his gaze sweep over the gloomy old house.

Something flashed at the edge of his vision.

Duncan quickly looked in that direction but saw only an empty corner.

But he was sure he really had seen something just now. There had been a figure… who looked like a maid in a black and white dress.

That figure had no head. At the collar of her blouse there was only a bare neck.

Duncan stood in the empty hall for a moment, carefully observing the surroundings and sensing the faint, uneasy aura drifting in the air. Then he began to walk toward the spiral staircase that wound upward at the end of the hall.

He had to figure out what this place was—why had winding up Alice brought him here?

He went up the spiral stairs. The steps, which felt as if they had been abandoned for countless years, creaked strangely under his feet. As he walked, a sense of familiarity suddenly rose in his heart.

He stopped abruptly and widened his eyes at the furnishings and style of the mansion.

He knew where that familiar feeling came from.

The room where Ray Nora, the Frostholm Queen, had slept!

Chapter 490: Strange Manor

Duncan stood at the top of the tall spiral staircase, looking down over the old yet splendid mansion. He once again confirmed his judgment: this mysterious house was almost exactly the same in style as the room where Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm had been sleeping before.

A thought flashed through his mind. He turned around at once and looked toward the other side at the top of the spiral stairs.

Over there was a deep corridor on the second floor. Strange paintings whose details could not be made out hung on both walls. Between the canvases stood iron candleholders as black as thorns. Pale flames burned on the candles, filling the corridor with dim, muddled light. At the very end of the passage, in the hazy darkness of the shadows, there seemed to be a faint suggestion of a door.

Was that the room of the manor’s Master?

Duncan moved at once, striding toward the depths of the dim corridor. The old wooden floorboards creaked in a dull rhythm under his feet. The pale candles on both sides of the hall seemed to sway in an unfelt breeze stirred up by his passing, rocking erratically. The already gloomy corridor filled with shifting light and shadow, and it looked even darker and more indistinct.

At the end of the corridor, Duncan stopped. His brows knit tightly as he stared into the darkness before him.

There was no door here. The big door he had seen in the shadows moments ago seemed to have been nothing but a fleeting illusion. In front of him was only a corridor that ended abruptly. The floor, walls, and ceiling all ended in a jagged break, as if torn apart. Beyond that break lay only a hollow, terrifying expanse of darkness.

Duncan stepped carefully to the edge of the broken floor, leaned forward to look out, then turned his head to study the area around the fracture.

Outside was a boundless void. The corridor under his feet floated alone in empty air with nothing to support it. There was no sign of any other part of the mansion around it, and no trace of the room and door that should have stood at the end of the hallway.

Duncan stepped back and quietly watched this empty gap.

There should have been something here: a room, a door. Now it was gone, as if it had been torn out of the manor and vanished into that void.

Suddenly, a faint rustling noise sounded nearby and broke Duncan’s thoughts.

He snapped his head toward the source of the sound.

A headless figure in a black coat stood by the wall not far away, bent over and carefully wiping a marble side table.

Duncan hesitated for only a moment, then walked toward the headless figure.

The headless figure did not flee like the fleeting shadows he had seen before. Instead, it slowly straightened up. When Duncan drew near, it even gave a slight bow, adopting the proper posture of a well-trained Butler.

But the smooth nothingness above its shoulders only made that polite posture even more eerie and frightening.

“Guest, who are you looking for?” A hollow, muffled voice came from the chest of the headless body. It sounded very courteous.

A strange feeling rose in his chest, but Duncan had dealt with plenty of uncanny things in this world. He soon pushed the weirdness aside and spoke calmly to the headless body before him: “Why is the room at the end of the corridor gone?”

“It left,” the headless body replied. “It left a very, very long time ago.”

Duncan frowned and asked at once: “What about the person in that room? There was supposed to be someone there, right?”

“The room’s Mistress left as well. She left together with the room, a very, very long time ago,” the headless body said.

“A very, very long time ago?” Duncan could not shake the sense of wrongness. “Not just now?”

“Yes, guest. Just now is the same as a very, very long time ago,” the headless body answered politely. “Here, anything that has already happened took place a very, very long time ago. The next thing will happen a very, very long time from now.”

The headless body’s words were strange and hard to understand, yet they stirred many guesses in Duncan’s mind. A break in time? A fault? Was this mansion caught inside some kind of Time Fracture?

Duncan suddenly thought of the brass key. He had come to this bizarre manor only after turning the key, and that brass key had come from a clear-minded Ender, a member of a group whose time did not flow normally.

The brass key?

Duncan’s heart stirred. He suddenly sensed something and looked down at his own hand. The cold touch seemed to arrive late, then suddenly flooded

his palm. A brass key lay there quietly.

As he saw the brass key, the headless body opposite him seemed to notice it as well. The figure gave a small shake, and that dull voice came again from its chest: “Ah, so you are an honored guest who carries the key. Forgive my poor service. May I ask if you have come to see the Mistress?”

“‘Mistress?’” Duncan was puzzled. “Didn’t you just say the Mistress left together with the room? And that it happened a very, very long time ago…”

“There are two Mistresses,” the headless body said slowly, like a patient Butler answering a guest’s questions. “One is the Mistress of the room. She never left her room, and now she has gone with it. The other is the Mistress of the manor. She never enters the manor.”

The headless body’s words grew stranger and stranger, leaving Duncan even more confused. Still, he quickly guessed that the “Mistress who never left her room” had to be Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm. A vague idea about the other “Mistress” began to form in his mind as well.

“What is the other Mistress called?” he asked, staring at the headless figure in front of him.

“This is the Alice Manor,” the headless body answered at once. “The Mistress’s name is, of course, Alice.”

Duncan lowered his eyelids without a change in expression, hiding the tiny shift in his gaze.

Everything was just as he had expected. He had entered this mansion only after turning the key in the keyhole on Alice’s back, so how could this strange house have nothing to do with Alice?

The mansion was called the Alice Manor. Alice was the true Mistress of this house, while Ray Nora was only the Mistress of that one room. Since Ray Nora never set foot outside her room, she sounded less like a “Mistress”

and more like a special prisoner. That fit what Ray Nora herself had revealed:

she had been bound to the “Drifting Land” in order to keep the “Elder Gods replicant” in The Deep Sea under control.

Now, with the “help” of some Subspace shadows, this special prisoner had escaped together with her cage.

And the “warden” of this prison was wandering outside the jail?

Duncan could not help picturing Alice’s simple, cheerful smile. No matter how he tried, he could not link that silly doll with roles like “Mistress of the Alice Manor” or “warden of the Drifting Land.”

So he forced down his wandering thoughts, arranged his expression, and lifted his eyes to the headless body in front of him: “Why does the manor’s Mistress never enter the manor?”

“She is resting in the garden,” the headless body replied. “She has been resting for a long time, but it is not yet time for her to return to the manor.”

“Resting in the garden?”

Duncan’s thoughts turned, though his face stayed calm. “May I go see that ‘Mistress’?”

“Of course,” the headless body said at once. Though it had no head, Duncan still felt as if a “gaze” fell on the brass key in his hand. “You are a guest who holds the key. You can open any door in this manor, including the one that leads to the garden. Please follow me. I will take you there.”

Duncan gave a soft “mm” of agreement, then followed behind the headless body toward the spiral stairs that connected the first and second floors.

On the way to the garden, he tried to gather as much information as he could by making small talk: “What is your position here?”

“I am the Butler here, guest,” said the headless body that called itself the Butler. “Ordinary attendants and maids do not dare approach you, so I came instead.”

“There are many attendants and maids here?” Duncan remembered the whispers he had heard earlier in the hall and the glimpsed phantoms. “It sounds quite lively in this place most of the time.”

“The Drifting Land accepts Drifters, and all souls who stumble into this place. Here, none of them have any home to go back to. So at the very least, it is a decent Sanctuary World.”

“What is your name?” Duncan asked again.

“I have no name, guest. You may simply call me the Butler,” the headless Butler said. “Most attendants and maids here have no names. Those who do will lose them in time. The Displaced will all lose their names in the end. That is our fate. I was one of the first to arrive here. My name was lost long ago.”

“The Displaced…” Duncan stopped walking without thinking, repeating the word under his breath.

“Guest?” The headless Butler also stopped and turned, as if looking at Duncan in curiosity.

“It’s nothing. I just drifted off for a moment,” Duncan said quickly, shaking his head.

But just as he was about to move again, a painting on the nearby wall suddenly caught his eye.

Chapter 491: Deep in the Garden

It was a large oil painting dominated by black and red tones, hanging on the wall closest to the spiral stairs.

Like most of the paintings in this manor, it looked blurred and chaotic. Rough, eerie lines and blocks of color covered the surface, making anyone who laid a gaze upon it feel dizzy and unable to make out anything meaningful, like graffiti scribbled by a madman in a hallucinatory runaway state.

Yet when Duncan’s gaze lingered on the painting and he stared at it for a long time, he suddenly noticed that something in the dark, muddled colors seemed to be slowly changing. Lines emerged from the shadows, and amid the chaotic colors, shapes slowly became recognizable.

It was as if a mass of burning fire appeared there. In the flames, something like the hull of a ship was wrapped up, slicing through the sky from heavy clouds as it fell toward the sea. The fire split the sky in two. The sea under it boiled and surged under the impact of the flames. Behind that fire, a dark red chaos pressed closer, gloomy and oppressive, like Doomsday itself chasing after it.

The entire image was still blurry. Everything remained extremely abstract and jumbled, yet that hazy scene still made Duncan’s eyes shift at once.

He instinctively recalled the scene he had seen earlier in a vision: a burning Three-Spindle Starship falling from the sky and breaking apart in explosions as it plunged into the sea.

Duncan came to a full stop and turned to study the scene on the oil painting in detail.

Soon he realized that the scene in the painting was not exactly the same as what he had seen in his vision. The ship in his vision had a clear style. At a glance you could see its transcendent technology and imposing size. But the “thing wrapped in flames” on the painting only had a vague ship-like shape. That hull even seemed to be made of wood. The fire around it also looked like simple burning, not the exhaust plume behind a starship.

It gave him the feeling that a painter from the Middle Ages, half a madman, had accidentally seen a spaceship from the future in a dream, yet could not understand what it really was. When he woke the next day, he could only rely on the faint memory of that dream, and on his limited knowledge and imagination, to recreate a rough, distorted version of it on the canvas.

The headless Butler’s voice came from behind him: “Guest, are you interested in this painting?”

“…Where did all the paintings here come from?”

“They have been here from the very beginning, guest,” the headless Butler said.

“The beginning?” Duncan echoed, puzzled. “When was that? When this ‘Alice Manor’ came into being? When ‘Alice’ became the Mistress here?”

“From the Dawn of Time,” the headless Butler said patiently. “Earlier than everything else.”

What kind of answer was that supposed to be?

Duncan frowned without thinking. The headless Butler’s reply sounded no different from saying nothing at all. Yet as he stared at that polite figure, he could not read any feeling from its posture. A person without a head had no

expression and no eyes, only courteous, well-mannered words filled with hollow eagerness.

After thinking for a while, Duncan asked two more questions: “Does this painting have a title? Do you know what it is depicting?”

“It has no name. None of the paintings here have names. They exist naturally. They do not need names or explanations. As for what the scene describes… I am sorry. That is beyond my knowledge.”

“Aren’t you the Butler here? You don’t understand the situation of this manor?”

“I am only a servant. This manor has countless secrets of its own, and it keeps them. Those are not matters a servant should know.”

Duncan’s mouth twitched.

He had the sudden urge to set a little fire on this Butler, but he forced that dangerous thought down in the next second.

It was because this was the Alice Manor, and this Butler was part of the manor itself. He had to be very careful with anything he did here, and avoid causing any harm to Alice.

Duncan drew in a slow breath to calm himself, and let his gaze sweep over the other paintings hanging in the corridor. There were countless canvases here, covered in colors that were hard to understand.

But none of the other paintings changed under his gaze.

“…Let’s go,” Duncan said at last, pulling his gaze away with a hint of regret. He spoke to the headless Butler: “Take me to this ‘garden’ you mentioned.”

The headless Butler gave a small bow and turned to lead the way again. He guided Duncan across the second-floor landing and down the spiral stairs,

then turned toward the depths of the first-floor hall. There a short passage led to the manor's back garden.

But Duncan stopped in front of the passage and turned his head to look curiously toward the other side of the hall. At the end of a long red carpet stood a very tall, grand dark wooden door. Narrow windows flanked it, and outside them seemed to be a tangle of thorns.

It looked like the "main entrance" of the entire building.

"What lies beyond that door?" Duncan suddenly asked.

At his words, the headless Butler's body visibly shuddered. In the next second, the calm and gentle tone he had kept all along turned anxious for the first time. "You must not show any interest in what lies beyond that door, guest! Beyond it is a place of no return. Anyone who goes there will never come back!"

"A place of no return?" Duncan's expression grew serious. "Why do you say that? Is it Subspace out there?"

"Subspace? I do not understand what that means… but you must never try to open that door!" The headless Butler waved its hands in panic. "It is the greatest taboo of the manor. No member may open that door under any circumstances…"

"But I am not a member here," Duncan said. Seeing the reaction, he even let some eager curiosity show on purpose. It was the first time he had seen the headless Butler so flustered, and it felt like a breakthrough for gathering information. "And you said yourself at the start that I hold the key, so I can open any door here."

"The key in your hand certainly can… but you must not do that!" the headless Butler cried. It seemed to want to block him more firmly, but perhaps some restriction held it back. It could only wave its arms about a

meter away from Duncan and try to stop him with words. “Do not open that door, for the sake of all the crew…”

“What is really beyond that door?” Duncan stared at the headless Butler, his voice extremely serious.

“Beyond that door… beyond that door…” The headless Butler hesitated, as if struggling to find the right words. “Guest, the world outside that door has already been wiped out. The end of all things is drawing near. The door holds back Doomsday itself. Do not open it. Do not let Doomsday come in…”

Duncan frowned as he listened to the headless Butler’s tense, panicked words, trying hard to fit them together with what he already knew about this world.

The world outside the door has already been wiped out… the end of all things is drawing near…

He pondered with furrowed brows for a long time, then let out a quiet breath.

“Relax. I do not plan to open that door.”

After pressing down the tangle of thoughts in his heart, he gave the headless Butler a small nod as he spoke.

The other relaxed at once. Even without a head, without any “expression,” Duncan could see the release in its whole body.

“You really frightened me, guest,” the Butler said, turning to lead the way again. “Please never joke like that again. We must keep Doomsday from crossing that door. It has already destroyed everything in the world. This place is the last barrier left…”

Duncan listened in silence to the Butler’s nervous muttering, full of lingering fear, and followed without a word. They passed through the short corridor and finally arrived at a rather narrow door. It was made of large panes of translucent glass reinforced with steel. Black steel frames divided the door into many geometric shapes of different sizes. In each shape, someone had drawn flowers and plants in a doodle-like style. The overall look… carried a bizarre mix of fairy tale and horror.

“The Mistress is in the garden. Please go in as you like.”

The headless Butler stepped forward, turned the handle of the garden door, then turned back to speak to Duncan.

“You are not coming with me?” Duncan asked, a little surprised.

“The garden is open only to the Mistress and to the Visitor who holds the key. The gardener enters only when necessary,” the headless Butler said. “Please go in without worry. If you need anything, just pull the cord by the door. I will be waiting here for you.”

“…Understood. Thank you for leading the way.”

Duncan gave the strange Butler a nod, then paid no more attention to its reaction. He stepped forward and gently pushed open the garden door.

A faint creak broke the silence between the manor and the garden.

Duncan stepped through the doorway, and incredible sunlight flooded his vision.

sunlight!

Deep inside this gloomy manor filled with eerie shadows, there was actually a garden bathed in sunlight?!

Still a little stunned, Duncan stepped forward. Lush plants came into view. Neatly arranged flowerbeds, well-trimmed shrubs, and paths framed by

green grass all looked pleasant to the eye. Above this vibrant garden, warm light shone down…

Duncan lifted his head. His surprised expression slowly turned into a frown.

He saw an extremely bizarre “sky.” Against a pale background, many childlike strokes floated overhead, depicting blue sky, white clouds, and a crude Sun. Around the Sun, someone had drawn many golden lines to stand for scattered sunlight.

The warm “sunlight” shining over the whole garden was being emitted by that ridiculous doodle of a Sun.

A thread of wariness rose in Duncan’s heart. The sky above the “garden” no longer felt warm to him. It only held endless strangeness.

He lowered his gaze from the sky and, with great caution, began to examine the garden itself.

A patch of odd color at the end of a path drew his attention.

He walked quickly toward it, went around a shrub and a low flower wall, and finally saw the source of that different color.

Where several paths met, at the center of a clearing deep in the garden, a figure sat quietly. The figure leaned back against a marble column wrapped in flowering vines, as if in a deep sleep.

And many black thorns spread out from the vines and wound around her whole body.

“…Alice?”

Chapter 492: Doll’s Drawing Board

When Duncan saw the quietly sleeping figure in the garden, he instinctively called out that familiar name.

But he stopped at once and remembered the scene from not long ago, when he had seen Queen Ray Nora in that lavish bedchamber—he could not have mistaken someone again, could he?

A strange feeling rose in Duncan’s heart. He walked carefully to the sleeping figure, bent down, and examined her closely.

He noticed the ball joints at her hands and feet, and the clear lack of any blood color. Her “skin” was pure white, with a texture like porcelain.

It really was Alice.

Duncan finally confirmed that the one sleeping here was indeed the Brother Doll he knew so well. He let out a long breath of relief. Then his attention shifted to the black brambles wrapped around her body.

Thorny vines stretched out from the flowerbeds and spread across the open ground around the Doll, like the train of a gorgeous yet eerie dress. The thorns had wrapped around the Doll’s hands, feet, and torso, binding her among the flowering vines.

Alice slept in the middle of this “bed” woven from flowers and thorns. She did not respond at all to Duncan’s approach and calls.

Duncan carefully avoided the thorny vines and the crisscrossing brambles. He reached out and lightly touched the Doll’s cheek, calling her name

again: “Alice, can you hear me?”

A faint coolness came from the skin under his fingertips, but Alice still gave no response. She simply slept in silence, like… a real, lifeless doll.

Duncan frowned slightly, and then he noticed something else.

The sleeping “Alice” was holding something in her arms. It looked like a drawing board. Brambles wrapped around her arm, but the drawing board seemed as if it could be pulled out through a gap.

Duncan hesitated for a moment. Then he reached out, grabbed the edge of the drawing board, and carefully pulled it, inch by inch, from her arms.

During the whole process, he kept watching Alice, checking what effect taking the drawing board away would have on her—the Doll went on sleeping.

Duncan let out a small sigh of relief and looked down at the drawing board he had pulled free.

A “painting” of bright colors and messy lines came into view. Like the strange “sky” above the garden, the childish strokes on the drawing board formed an abstract picture.

There was a vortex, a swirl made of many colors patched together. It took up almost two-thirds of the whole board. Around the vortex were many tiny dots of light. The “artist” had drawn many crossed lines to show that these dots were shining stars.

At the center of the colorful vortex, he could see a deep patch of red light. Even though the doodle was simple, Duncan still felt a strong… danger coming from that red patch.

He frowned. For some reason, the red glow in the vortex felt familiar.

He searched his mind for a long time before he found the source of that familiarity. It was on the second-floor platform of “Alice Mansion”, on the wall near the spiral staircase. There hung an oil painting that showed a burning giant ship falling from the sky. In the sky behind the huge ship, the same dark red glow spread, filling the scene with unease.

Duncan’s expression grew more and more serious.

This was already the second time… In this strange “Alice Mansion”, that dark red light full of bad omens had appeared again. What did this dark red glow actually represent?

Was it a sign of some disaster that kept chasing them, drawing closer and closer? Or was it a true picture of some phenomenon that would appear when Doomsday came?

The headless Butler had warned him many times not to open the mansion’s front door… What was outside that door? Was it the true body of this “dark red glow”?

Dangerous thoughts rose in his heart for a moment, but Duncan pushed them down at once.

He was indeed very curious about what lay beyond the front door of Alice Mansion. But curiosity was not the same as recklessness. Before he had more clues and had confirmed Alice’s safety, he would try his best not to disturb the “order” inside this “mansion”.

His thoughts slowly calmed. Duncan let out a breath, looked up at the doodle-like sky above the garden, then lowered his head to the doodle-like drawing board in his hands.

The Doll still slept quietly among the flowers beside him, as if she were holding all the secrets and keeping all the answers sealed.

Who had “created” the sky here and the doodles on the drawing board? Was it this sleeping Doll? Was it Alice?

Duncan recalled the information he had heard from Ray Nora and suddenly felt that Alice was not like the Frostholm Queen imagined, not just a mistaken replica mixed from “Ray Nora” and the “Guillotine”.

Or rather… the body of Miss Doll might indeed have come from such a process, but inside, she clearly hid secrets far greater than that outer shell.

This grand, eerie “Alice Mansion”, and the Doll sleeping quietly in this garden, were her “inner self”. And these secrets clearly went far beyond what Ray Nora knew.

It was a simple truth: if a copied file carried more information than the original, then there was only one possibility—during the “copy” process, someone had written something else into that “file”.

Thoughts flowed through Duncan’s mind. After he had sat in silence for a long time, he sighed and prepared to put the drawing board back into the Doll’s hands.

Putting things back where they belonged and avoiding changes—that was necessary caution.

But just as he turned the drawing board around to push it back, some uneven marks on the back suddenly caught his eye.

Duncan’s gaze tightened. He quickly lifted the drawing board up again and studied the back, which he had ignored at first.

The uneven marks were a line of words carved deep into the frame on the back of the drawing board—

“…The Messenger brought news from afar, and the chosen clan picked up the lost Ancient Star and forged it into the crown of divine blessing—the

Third Long Night came to an end.”

Duncan’s eyes stayed on that ancient, graceful line of text for a long time. His expression did not change for a while.

He did not know how long had passed before he gently let out a breath, bent down, avoided the thorns and vines, and slowly put the drawing board back into the Doll’s hands.

Yet in his mind, the sentence on the back of the drawing board kept circling, replaying again and again.

The chosen clan… the Ancient Star… the end of the Third Long Night…

Duncan stood up, his face thoughtful. In his mind, the pieces of known information began to rearrange and link together.

The “Third Long Night” was the most important clue. In that copy of *The Blasphemous Tome* held by the Annihilators, which very likely hid the true history, it was written that the age of the Deep Sea began only after the Third Long Night was safely passed. The whole world had survived from that time until now.

And the only “chosen clan” that could match the “Third Long Night” was the group who founded the ancient kingdom of Critt, those mysterious ancient Sages.

Picking up the lost Ancient Star…

Could these words be describing the historical event of the ancient kingdom of Critt forging Vision 001 – the Sun?

Sadly… there was too little information. Just one unclear “message” could not do more than spark a few vague guesses. It was useless beyond that.

Duncan shook his head and pushed this regret aside for now. Then he carefully searched the garden again, a place full of life yet thick with a

strange mood.

He did not find anything else worth noting. In this large garden, besides the sleeping Doll, there were only lush plants and neat, well-kept paths.

At last, he returned to the side of the “sleeping Doll”.

After he walked a full circle around this dormant “Alice”, he suddenly stopped behind her.

A Keyhole.

It was not on her back under her clothes, but at the exposed nape of her neck. On the back of the sleeping Doll’s neck, a familiar Keyhole caught Duncan’s eye.

He moved closer without thinking and studied the small Keyhole.

So the Doll in the garden also had a Keyhole… But why was it in a different place from Alice’s? Did this difference in location have some symbolic meaning?

After seeing so many strange and uncanny things in this world, Duncan now often thought first of “symbolic meaning” and such. But he quickly put away these questions that clearly had no answer for now and hesitated as he took out the brass key he carried.

Ever since he had entered Alice Mansion, this key had appeared in his hand for no clear reason… Was it meant to be used here?

This thought flashed through Duncan’s mind. Then he made up his mind and slowly brought the key to the Keyhole at the back of the sleeping Doll’s neck. He carefully slid it in.

With a light click, the key bit into something inside. At once, it began to turn on its own, just as it had before.

That familiar feeling rushed at him from all directions. Light and shadow swapped places. His senses reshaped themselves. After a moment of weightlessness came the feeling of solid ground under his feet.

In almost the blink of an eye, the world around Duncan turned back into the captain's cabin on the Vanished that he knew so well.

A smooth, white back appeared before his eyes. Alice still sat obediently on the round stool, waiting for her captain to wind her up.

Duncan stared, stunned. He looked at the scene in front of him in a daze for several seconds before his thoughts caught up. Then a strange idea popped into his head— "Such a nice back… It would be a shame not to put a few cupping jars on it…"

Alice heard the quiet muttering behind her. She clutched her clothes and carefully turned her head. "Eh? Captain, what did you say?"

"Nothing," Duncan snapped back to himself at once. He hurriedly cleared his throat twice to cover that flash of embarrassment, then pulled the key out of the Keyhole. "It's done. You don't feel uncomfortable, do you?"

"Huh?" Alice clearly froze for a second. She reached for the zipper on her back, then looked over at him in surprise. "Didn't we just start?"

Duncan's hand paused as he put the key away.

He had stayed in "Alice Mansion" for so long… but in the Mortal Realm, only an instant had passed?

Chapter 493: The Stolen Room

With countless questions and guesses in his heart, Duncan tucked the brass key safely close to his body. Alice stood obediently beside him, her eyes darting back and forth like a child waiting to hear a secret.

“Do you feel anything different now?” Duncan asked, looking into Alice’s eyes.

“Something different?” Alice tilted her head. She reached back and touched her spine. After a moment she shook her head. “Just now the Keyhole felt a bit itchy, but it doesn’t itch anymore.”

Duncan frowned. “Nothing else? That’s it?”

“That’s it,” Alice answered honestly. Then she looked a little curious. “Was there supposed to be something? Your face looks so serious… Did you figure out the key?”

Duncan’s brow stayed tightly furrowed. After hesitating for a short while, he finally sorted out his thoughts and words. He sat down on the bed opposite the Doll and spoke with a very serious face: “You may have felt only an instant pass, but I stayed in a strange place for a long time. It was an old, huge manor. Its name… was ‘Alice Mansion’.”

The Brother Doll widened her eyes bit by bit. She listened to the captain’s story in surprise and confusion.

Duncan did not hide his experiences in Alice Mansion. He told Miss Doll in front of him everything he had seen and heard there. Then he spoke of what

he had seen and heard in the Deep Sea as well, including his meeting with Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm.

Of course, he knew Alice might only understand part of it, and even the part she understood would be muddled. She would not remember much afterward. But he still chose to tell her everything.

Because these were things she should know. He could not think, “She won’t understand anyway,” and hide it all from her. That would have been the bare minimum of respect lost.

Alice listened in a daze all the way to the end. Even after Duncan finished speaking, it took another ten seconds before the Brother Doll finally came back to herself. “…Wow.”

Then she scratched her hair, looking puzzled and a little apologetic. “I… don’t really get it. My head feels all blurry… Sorry, Captain. You worked so hard to help me understand all this, but I think I’m a bit dumb…”

“No, you’re not dumb. These things are just too complicated,” Duncan said, already expecting this reaction from her. He smiled and shook his head. “Even I feel that everything about this is full of riddles. There are too many clues and they’re too scattered. We’re still a long way from tearing open the final fog.”

Alice nodded, half understanding and half not. She thought seriously for a while, then suddenly asked with some curiosity: “Were there a lot of people in that ‘mansion’? And none of them had heads?”

“I only saw one person who called himself the Butler. But from what the Butler said, there really were many people in the mansion. They were all just hiding,” Duncan said, thinking back. “From what I saw, they should all have been headless Attendants.”

Alice frowned. She tried hard to think as she muttered, “Could it have something to do with my ‘Decapitation’ ability…?”

“That’s possible. I can’t rule out that some of the Attendants are the souls of people you once decapitated,” Duncan said. As someone who knew about “Alice’s Guillotine”, he had naturally thought along that line. But then he changed direction. “However, from some of the information the Butler gave me, the mansion has also gathered many souls that ‘drifted’ and came together. They’re like some kind of wandering dead who receive the mansion’s shelter. Those Attendants don’t seem like they were decapitated…”

He paused and thought for a moment before going on: “Maybe your Guillotine ability makes all the souls gathered in the mansion appear headless, no matter what their original ‘source’ is.”

“Oh…” Alice seemed to understand. Then something else seemed to occur to her. “What about that ‘Frostholm Queen’? Did she really just disappear?”

“The room really did vanish,” Duncan nodded. “It looked just like she said. Once the Elder Gods’ tentacles that acted as ‘connection points’ were destroyed, the ‘drifting land’ would lose its anchor, like a ship whose mooring lines have been cut, and…”

He suddenly fell silent. His expression turned thoughtful.

“Captain?” Alice looked at Duncan, puzzled. “Why did you stop talking?”

She asked twice in a row before Duncan lifted his head from his thoughts. His tone held a trace of weight. “I’m wondering whether the ‘drifting land’ Ray Nora spoke of refers to her room or to the entire Alice Mansion.”

“Eh?” Alice froze. “Is there a difference?”

“If the drifting land means the entire Alice Mansion, then when the ‘connection point’ was burned by me, the thing that should have

disappeared was the whole manor, not just one room on the second floor," Duncan said slowly. "But if the drifting land refers only to the room where she slept, then what exactly is the relationship between that room and the rest of the manor? Or to put it another way… doesn't the 'connection' between her room and the whole mansion also count as a 'connection point'?"

He paused here and lifted his hand to point at Alice.

"More importantly, after I turned the winding key in you, I entered that 'Alice Mansion'. It's obvious that the bond between that manor and you is the strongest. You and it should even be some kind of 'one mind, one body'. If the 'drifting land' needs a connection point to exist in a stable way… then you are clearly the most stable connection point."

Alice blinked hard and listened carefully, trying her best to understand—but she failed.

Still, her strength had always been honesty. "What are you talking about?"

"The room where the Frostholm Queen slept had been 'torn' away from the main body of the mansion. The edges showed clear damage. At first I didn't pay much attention to that, but just now I suddenly realized… Ray Nora may have hidden some things from me.

"In theory, the so-called 'drifting land' should be the entire Alice Mansion. That manor is closely linked to you, and from what I saw, it did not show any tendency to 'drift'. So it's very likely that Ray Nora took advantage of the moment when I burned the Elder Gods' tentacles—when some of the 'connections' weakened—to forcefully separate her room from the main body of the mansion."

Alice continued trying to understand.

This time, she finally managed most of it.

“So you mean the Frostholm Queen used your fire as a chance to ‘sail’ her room away? Like taking the lifeboat off a ship in thick fog?”

Duncan froze for a moment and looked at the Doll in mild surprise. “That’s actually a pretty fitting metaphor… How did you come up with it?”

“Mr. Goathead told me lots of stories like that,” Alice said earnestly. “Like mutinous sailors stealing the lifeboat in the fog, or stealing the wine barrels, or stealing the cheese, or stealing the salted fish. Then the wise and mighty captain would cross the whole Boundless Sea to take back the stolen salted fish… Are you going to catch that Frostholm Queen who stole the room?”

Duncan listened in a daze. When Alice finished, he finally smirked and twitched the corner of his mouth. “Let’s not even ask why the mutinous crew would steal salted fish, or why I would cross the whole Boundless Sea just to grab back a piece of salted fish—where would I even find that Frostholm Queen? Besides, if anyone is going to catch her, it should be you. She stole your room. You’re the Mistress of Alice Mansion.”

“…Right,” Alice said after thinking about it for a bit. She accepted the logic very simply, then shook her head. “Then I won’t chase her. That room was hers in the first place. But… why would she do that? You just said, once the drifting land loses its anchor, it’ll fly all over the place. It might even fall into Subspace, like exile—that’s really scary, isn’t it?”

Duncan could not help falling into thought. He spoke slowly as he pondered: “Yes… why indeed…”

He thought of the Ray Nora he had seen. He remembered that Frostholm Queen who seemed to have worn shackles since birth, who was crowned in chains and overthrown in chains. Even after falling into the Deep Sea, she was still locked in a nightmare.

She had said she slept in a cage all her life, even after the bars were taken away.

Now she had broken out of prison—with her cage in tow.

“Probably for ‘freedom’,” Duncan said softly.

But was it really only for “freedom”?

…

On the control console, the needles on the gauges shook rapidly. The shaking that came when they neared the surface grew more and more obvious. Through the thick glass porthole, the dark, boundless seawater around them already showed faint rays of light spilling down from above.

sunlight appeared in the water—this meant the submersible was quickly nearing the surface.

Yet the growing brightness could not fully drive away the oppressive mark left by the Deep Sea. It was as if something in the vast darkness below the submersible was still rising and spreading, still stretching out invisible tentacles, still reaching upward with unseen hands, trying to keep the uninvited guests who had once intruded into the Deep Sea.

The things Duncan had told her during the ascent still circled in her mind—horrifying, strange, unbelievable, shaking the very foundations of her beliefs.

Whether it was the soul of the Frostholm Queen, who had spent fifty years in a symbiotic pact with the Elder Gods in the Deep Sea, or the terrifying possibility hidden in all things of the mortal world, either alone was enough to make a person with firm will and devout faith feel an icy chill under the sunlight.

All things in the mortal world were Spawn of the Elder Gods. The Elder Gods' flesh and blood lived in all beings, and it was slowly waking.

Not even the most filthy, blasphemous, heretical tomes dared to record words like these. Even the craziest Annihilators had stopped at ideas like "the Abyssal Lord created the world".

The sunlight from the surface grew brighter and brighter.

Yet the already-dead body felt no warmth at all.

Agatha clasped her hands over her chest and silently called Bartok's name, wanting to offer a Prayer to her God.

But no matter what she did, she could not calm her heart.

Chapter 494: Gathering of the Followers

With a burst of spray and rippling seawater, the submersible broke through the surface.

Afternoon sunlight shone over the wide sea. The submersible's thick hull gleamed with a cold light under the sun. Then the disposable smoke device on top of the hull fired; with a flash and a soft bang, a column of orange smoke shot straight up into the blue sky.

After some time adjusting her trim and power, the submersible's floating state steadied. With creaks and groans, the locking mechanism on the side of the hull released. As the handle turned, Duncan pushed the hatch open from inside.

A rush of fresh air hit them in the face – even for two "corpses" who no longer needed to breathe, the cool, clean wind above the sea felt especially pleasant.

The illusion of being hunted, entangled, and held back by unspeakable things in the Deep Sea finally began to fade from their minds. Agatha gripped the handrail, climbed out of the hatch with Duncan, and csheepered onto the top of the submersible's hull, gazing out at the endless sea.

Duncan turned his head a little and looked at the Gatekeeper: "How does it feel to be back under the sunlight?"

“It feels as if I once again came back from the gate of the realm of death,” Agatha said softly. “I never thought sunlight and air could shake me like this, almost like being reborn – and yet I can no longer feel the warmth of the sunlight, nor enjoy smooth breathing.”

“And ‘her’?” Duncan asked again. “During the dive, the other Agatha never showed herself, but she must have been watching the whole time, right?”

“We feel much the same, but she said she needs some time to think about a few things, so she is staying quiet now – do you want to talk to her? I can call her out…”

“No need. Let her think,” Duncan waved his hand lightly. “This Deep Dive will reshape everyone’s views and be a kind of baptism. We all have a lot to think about.” He looked up at the distant horizon. “Oh, the recovery ship Tyrian sent has spotted us. Looks like we don’t need to make our own way back to the city-state.”

The silhouette of a steam launch appeared on the sea, heading quickly toward the trail of signal smoke rising from the submersible…

The submersible had returned safely, his Father and that Gatekeeper lady were unharmed and on their way back – when this “express dispatch” arrived on his desk through the pneumatic tube line, Tyrian, who had been waiting for news in South Harbor, could not help letting out a breath.

But right after that, a strange feeling rose from the bottom of his heart.

He stood up from behind his desk and slowly paced to the window, staring absentmindedly at the sunlight sinking outside. In the silence, Lucretia’s voice suddenly came from the scrying crystal not far away: “Is there news from Father?”

Tyrian glanced back at the glowing scrying crystal on his desk and spoke in a slightly odd tone: “You can tell… am I that obvious?”

Inside the scrying crystal, Lucretia had a piece of bread in her mouth. One hand was busy scribbling and calculating on a sheet of draft paper floating in the air beside her, while the other adjusted the instruments on her table. She still found time to glance up at her elder brother and mumble casually: “Thirty percent nervous, thirty percent hesitant, thirty percent relieved, and ten percent scared and lost – that has to mean Father is back.”

“…Do all you scholars talk to people like that? You make me sound like a pie chart.” Tyrian frowned, then could not help sighing. “I’m just a bit emotional. Not long ago, I would never have imagined feeling relieved because Father returned safe. The first time I heard he had ‘come back’, I was not in this frame of mind at all.”

“Right. Back then your legs almost cramped from fear. After you commanded the Sea Mist to fight Dad, you did not sleep for three days. In the middle of the night you dragged me out of bed to describe your nightmares and insisted I shiver along with you…”

“Stop! Don’t make up details that never happened!” Tyrian hurriedly cut off his younger sister in the scrying crystal. “And that is not even what I wanted to talk to you about!”

Lucretia quieted down. She finally set aside her never-ending research and the half-eaten bread, and looked up, staring seriously into Tyrian’s eyes.

When that divine gaze almost made Tyrian’s skin crawl, she finally broke the silence: “When we were little, Father often left home for very long trips. Whenever bells rang from the direction of the docks, we would climb up onto the roof to see if it was the flag of the Vanished. You always told me to act like a lady and be more steady, then took the chance to grab the highest spot.”

“…It has been many years,” Tyrian said after a few seconds of silence, almost like talking to himself. “I still remember the roof was blue. When

the sea wind blew, the weather vane on the eaves would whistle. You tied a pinwheel next to it and said you wanted to show it off to Father, and that was how our secret rooftop climbing got exposed."

"Now we have both risen to places higher than that old roof. We have seen the sights Father once saw," Lucretia said gently. "But we still have not caught up to his steps. He went into the Deep Sea, to depths even the Abyssal Trench Project in those days never reached… What do you think he will find on this expedition?"

Tyrian did not answer at once. In the next second, a crackling sound suddenly came from the mirror behind him, and Duncan's voice followed from within it: "I found an astonishing secret – and I am just about to tell you."

Tyrian almost jumped out of his skin, every muscle tensing. The Sea Witch on the other side of the scrying crystal reacted even more strongly – he heard a sharp cry from Lucretia's side and a loud clatter, then smoke and flashes flared inside the scrying crystal and the image cut off.

Still tense all over, Tyrian turned his head and saw ghost-green flame burning in the mirror behind him. In the dark mirror, Duncan leaned out and looked over Tyrian's shoulder: "Is your younger sister all right over there? Did I scare her?"

"Could you maybe stop using such frightening methods every time you show up…" Tyrian muttered without thinking. As soon as the words left his mouth, he felt they were improper, and quickly checked Duncan's reaction – his Father's face did not change.

"I did think about appearing in a friendlier way, like knocking first or sending a notice in advance," Duncan said calmly as he looked at Tyrian. "But Vanna told me it isn't the way I appear that's frightening; it's the fact

that I appear at all. I think she is right, so I decided not to change it – at least this way, watching everyone's startled reactions is a bit entertaining."

Tyrian's eye twitched. His Father's open attitude toward "enjoying the show" left him speechless, but he soon forced his emotions back into order. As he straightened his expression, he looked curiously at his Father in the mirror: "Have you already returned to the city-state? I will come to you now…"

"The avatar form I was using has returned, but you do not need to go there," Duncan interrupted him. "Pack a few things and go straight to the Vanished."

Tyrian froze. "Huh?"

"I made an important discovery in the Deep Sea," Duncan said, his expression especially serious. "The information must not be made public, and it may point toward the Elder Gods, so everyone must be summoned to the Vanished to discuss it. I have already sent Agatha over. My followers have gathered. You are the master of the Sea Mist and the new governor of Frostholm. You have to be there as well."

From his Father's look and tone, Tyrian at once understood how unusual and grave the matter was, and quickly put away his moment of relief: "All right. I will leave a note for Aiden to explain the situation first."

"Good." Duncan nodded, then let his gaze sweep over the room and settle on the complex crystal sphere and its lens array device.

"Bring your scrying crystal when you come aboard," he said to Tyrian. "It would be best if Lucy heard this as well – she will be interested in the secrets of the Deep Sea."

Tyrian, who was writing the note, immediately looked up when he heard this, first giving Duncan a surprised glance, then nodding at once: "All

right, I will definitely bring the scrying crystal. Where is the Vanished now? I will have a fast boat made ready…”

Before he could finish, Duncan waved a hand in the mirror: “No need. AI will take you.”

There was a knock-knock-knock at the window.

Tyrian turned toward the sound and saw the plump white dove that always followed his Father.

Outside, the dove pecked at the harbor office’s window with its beak, then tilted its head: “Coming aboard? Big seat! Veteran driver, nice and steady!”

Tyrian: “…”

…

The dining room of the Vanished was the gathering place for the crew.

The wide long table had been polished until it shone. Bright oil lamps hung from the pillars near the table, and the captain’s followers gathered on both sides. Vanna and Morris sat upright and proper. Shirley and Alice were off in their own worlds. Nina and Dog were each bent over a book. And besides them, there were two new figures here today.

Agatha, dressed like a blind nun, sat quietly at the long table in silent prayer, and beside her sat Lawrence, wrapped in a white coat and gripping his pipe, looking cramped and nervous.

The latter was nervously taking in every detail of the cabin.

Lawrence’s own ship was now anchored on the nearby sea. His first mate was handling things on board, while the captain himself had been ordered over to the “flagship”. No one had told him exactly what this was about on the way here, which left the old captain deeply uneasy.

This was the first time he had truly set foot on the Vanished, the legendary ghost ship that had returned from subspace. Duncan Abnomar’s followers gathered in this ancient, solemn cabin, waiting in the lamplight for Captain Duncan’s orders.

He already knew who these people were and where they came from –

a living doll, the shattered Sun, a demon with a soul, an Inquisitor who had broken her oath and gone into exile, a legendary scholar on the brink of madness…

Now he was among them.

Even in his wildest dreams and visions, Lawrence had never imagined he would live through a scene like this.

He was just an exploration-ship captain who had been ready to retire… so how had he ended up mixed into this?

Chapter 495: the Vanished's Eerie Yet Playful Mood

On one side of the long table, Lawrence carefully watched every move everyone made, while also cautiously controlling each of his own expressions and every muscle. He wondered how he should blend naturally into this special gathering without looking like… an outsider.

Stories about legendary investigators and legendary adventurers flooded into his mind, then rolled back like sea water over sand. They left behind a mess of stray thoughts, but nothing that was actually useful.

After letting his thoughts run wild for quite a while, he finally gathered a bit of courage and quietly asked Agatha, who sat closest to him: "When will Captain Duncan probably get here?"

"I do not know either. He said we have to wait for everyone to arrive," Agatha answered in a low voice. "Let's be patient."

"Are there any rules for later?" Lawrence asked softly again. "This is my first time at one of these meetings…"

"It is my first time too." Agatha folded her hands over her chest. She looked as if she were praying silently, but like Lawrence she was carefully watching everything in the cabin. Although she knew the faces around the long table, this was indeed her first visit to the ship. "But I do not think you need to be nervous. We have worked with each other in the city-state. Everyone is very friendly."

Lawrence made a small sound of understanding, but still could not sit still. He could not help glancing past her to Vanna, who sat one seat farther away – the Pland Inquisitor counted as something of an “acquaintance” of his: “Lady Inquisitor, this is my first time at a meeting. If I do anything rude later, please help me out…”

Before Vanna could answer, Shirley across the table suddenly cut in: “Huh? You want her to watch out for you being rude? Old man, let me tell you, when she loses her manners the noise she makes is way bigger than you. Back then she did a jumping chop and…”

“Ahem.” Vanna started coughing loudly at once, cutting off Shirley’s story. While Lawrence was still stunned, Nina across the table put down her book, looked around, and muttered: “I’m hungry. When are we eating?”

Shirley shook her head: “Dinner is still a long way off.”

Nina blinked. “Huh? Then why are we in the dining room?”

“The captain said there was something important to discuss. You did not hear?”

“I did not… I was busy reading. Uncle Duncan said to gather in the dining room, so I just brought my book over,” Nina said, her head swaying back and forth. “Who has food?”

“I have biscuits! And salted dried fish!” Alice jumped to her feet at once, happily pulling snacks from the pockets of her dress. “Who else wants some?”

Nina and Shirley pounced on her at once in excitement. Dragged by his chain, Dog tilted to the side, scratching at his chart paper with his paws while he shouted: “Hey, Shirley, at least say something before you get up! You made me skew my plotted course…”

Lawrence stared, dumbfounded, as the atmosphere in this gloomy, solemn meeting hall suddenly turned lively. He hesitated, then turned to glance at Morris, the only one still sitting upright. Morris took the pipe from his mouth, gave Lawrence a friendly nod, and said: “You will get used to it. The ship is like this every day. If you get hungry, just tell Alice – she is in charge of everyone’s meals.”

Lawrence felt his thoughts creak and turn halfway around. He spoke with some effort: “Uh, I… am not hungry.”

No sooner had the words left his mouth than he caught, from the corner of his eye, a flash of eerie green light near the dining-room doors. He tensed up at once, nerves jolted. But just as he was about to warn everyone, the doors opened, and the one who walked in was not the master of the Vanished.

Tyrian appeared in the doorway with a suitcase in hand, his steps a little unsteady, staring blankly at the scene in the dining room.

Shirley had climbed onto the table. Dog hung in midair. Nina was hanging off Alice. And Alice – the living doll who wore the face of Frostholm’s Queen – now held both hands high, one stuffed full of biscuits, the other crammed with dried fish.

The Gatekeeper of Frostholm and the Inquisitor of Pland sat expressionless on the far side of the table, quietly covering their foreheads with their hands.

Tyrian’s arrival drew everyone’s attention. Even Shirley, about to stuff more dried fish into her mouth, paused. Several gazes along the long table fell on Frostholm’s newly appointed governor all at once. The neat, unified stare made even the “Steel Vice Admiral”, who had weathered countless storms, step back half a pace without thinking.

But this was not Tyrian's first time seeing the Vanished's current atmosphere. He recovered quickly, adjusted his expression, and walked toward the long table while greeting everyone warmly. He was polite and well-mannered; no one looking at him now would have guessed that for the last half century he had roamed this Frost Sea as a pirate lord.

"Sorry, it took a bit of time to get my things together and kept everyone waiting," Tyrian said as he came to an empty seat at the long table. He set the rather heavy suitcase on the table, then looked around. "Has Father not arrived yet?"

Almost the instant the words left Tyrian's mouth, Duncan's voice suddenly sounded at the head of the long table: "I am here."

The next second, a mass of ghost-green flame flared out of thin air at the far end of the table. It surged upward and exploded, then fell toward the table. Within the fire, Duncan's figure took shape, solidified, and sat down in the chair that belonged to him at the head of the long table.

A moment later, with a few faint whooshing sounds, every light in the cabin took on a layer of eerie green radiance.

A low, unsettling creaking rose up from the depths of the ship.

Morris's expression changed slightly. He could feel it: the very "mood" of the ship was shifting.

The captain was adjusting the Vanished into some kind of… defensive posture!

Right after that, he heard the captain's voice speak from within the flames: "What I am going to say today is extremely special and dangerous, so we need the highest level of protection. From this moment on, the Vanished will sink into the Spirit Realm. During the meeting, those of you with firm faith, keep a close watch on your own mental state. When you hear secrets

that point toward a God, if you hear or see any ‘revelation’, report it to me at once.”

Vanna, Morris, and Agatha glanced at one another without thinking. They hesitated only for a heartbeat, then nodded slightly.

Duncan’s gaze fell on Tyrian: “Did you bring the scrying crystal?”

“Yes.” Tyrian spoke at once, then lifted his hand to open the heavy case he had brought. Inside lay the scrying crystal that held extraordinary power and the complex lens array device. He began to work the intricate mechanisms on the lens base, setting each lens into its proper place.

In the next moment, the scrying crystal slowly began to glow.

After a short wait, a blurry human shape appeared in the faint light, then quickly came into focus.

Lucretia’s figure appeared inside the scrying crystal – for one brief instant, then the picture flickered and vanished.

Nina, who was leaning over beside it, watching curiously, was instantly baffled. She turned to Tyrian: “Did it break?”

Tyrian rubbed his chin in some embarrassment: “…She fell off her chair.”

No sooner had he spoken than rustling and the sound of clutter being pushed aside came from inside the scrying crystal. Lucretia finally appeared again in the center of the image. The Sea Witch stared at the scene on this side of the crystal with a look of shocked tension, then glared at Tyrian: “Brother! What are you doing?!”

“It was I who told him to bring the crystal to the Vanished, Lucy,” Duncan’s voice came from the side before Tyrian could speak. “But I did not expect him to forget to warn you in advance. Do not be afraid. Talking with your own Father for a few minutes is not enough for the curse to cling to you.”

Lucretia’s expression in the scrying crystal looked strange. She clearly had not been ready for this sudden meeting and conversation, and seemed a little ill at ease. But she quickly sensed the unusually serious mood on this side. Her small unease was pressed down at once and replaced by an effort to regain her composure: “Father, it has been a long time. I am sorry, I did not mean to…”

“It has not actually been that long – do not worry about it. I understand your reaction.” Duncan gave a small smile, then lifted his head and gestured to the others around the long table. “Let us start with a brief introduction, Lucy. These are the Vanished’s new crew members, and the new captain of the Vanished Fleet…”

He introduced the people around the long table one by one. Those he called by name stood up and nodded in greeting. At last he pointed at the figure in the scrying crystal: “This is my daughter, Lucretia – many of you should already know of her, so there is no need to say much more.”

“The famous Frontier Adventurer, the Sea Witch who has made great contributions in the field of occult studies,” Morris said with an immediate nod. “It is an honor to meet you, my lady.”

Lucretia gave a reserved little nod: “I have heard your name as well. Even in Lightwind Harbor and Morka, the senior professors of Truth Academy often quote many of your results and views when they are discussing problems.”

Once she calmed down, the Sea Witch looked dignified and steady. She sat straight within the scrying crystal, every small movement showing confidence and grace.

She did not look at all like someone who had just fallen out of her chair.

“All right, that is enough introductions and small talk,” Duncan cut in at the right moment. “Now for the real business.”

His gaze swept over everyone present.

Everyone had arrived.

Even Goathead, who could not leave the captain’s cabin, was listening in with Duncan’s permission.

Duncan let out a light breath and broke the silence:

“To put it simply, Agatha and I successfully carried out a Deep Dive beneath Frostholm. Our exact depth surpassed that of the Abyssal Trench Project half a century ago. During the Deep Dive, we saw many horrifying scenes and learned truths enough to overturn many people’s understanding.

“First, we confirmed the structure at the bottom of the city-state – there is some kind of enormous biological mass down there…”

Chapter 496: Duncan’s Bold Idea

As the eerie green flame lit the cabin, the distant sound of waves outside the hull slowly seemed to come from a hazy, dreamlike place, and the secrets from the endless Deep Sea, from that dark and frozen region, seeped into everyone’s mind like terrifying shadows.

The only shelters mortals had on the Boundless Sea were all built on the corpses of unspeakable giant beasts—their withered tentacles hung from the undersides of the city-states, and their pale, horrible eyes cast a gaze into the bottomless ocean trench.

All living beings in the mortal world were Spawn of the Abyssal Lord, and the flesh of the Elder Gods formed everything in existence. What had happened in Frostholm had not been a simple invasion, but the Elder Gods “waking” from their own creations.

The Four Gods were not necessarily a stable embodiment of order. They too might fall into a corrupted runaway state, and a similar “runaway state” might already have happened more than once in this world. The reason the mortal world was now under the protection of the Four Gods might simply be that, among all the Gods, only they still remained awake.

The catastrophe in Frostholm would not be the last. As the condition of the Abyssal Lord worsened, and as the flaws in the “creation Blueprint” grew over time, similar “awakenings” were very likely to break out across the world. Wrong “replicants” of the Elder Gods would crawl out of the Deep Sea, out from the depths beneath the city-states, and even… out from inside every mortal.

With a calm, steady tone, Duncan told his followers everything he had learned in the Deep Sea, and everything he had worked out from the information they already had.

After that, the cabin fell into a long, deathly silence.

Even thick-skulled Alice and carefree Shirley sat quietly for once, and they realized how serious the problem was… probably.

After a long time, Vanna finally broke the silence. She took a deep breath, a gloomy look gathering on her face like a dark cloud: “If I hadn’t heard this from you personally, I would have taken every line of this information as the mad ravings of a Ender…”

“Even the most deranged Ender probably couldn’t make up something on this level,” Morris said slowly. He lifted his pipe to his mouth, noticed that the tobacco inside had gone out at some point, and set it down again with a bitter smile. “Ah, right, the Enders… and the ones who dealt with the Queen of Frostholm. One of the craziest things in this world is that among those Subspace believers, there are actually some who can stay clear-headed…”

Tyrian frowned, stayed silent for a long time, then finally could not help looking up: “Father, is all this information real?”

As soon as he said it, he felt he had asked a stupid question, but right now this stupid question felt necessary—everyone at the long table probably had the same thought in mind.

“At the very least, this is indeed what I saw and heard,” Duncan said calmly. “Of course, limited information can be misleading. Even the clearest clues can be interpreted in several ways.

“Besides, the Queen of Frostholm might not have told us the whole truth. Even if she did, she could still be wrong herself—we can only use the

information we have right now to work out the possibility that is closest to the truth."

"The possibility that is closest to the truth right now…" Tyrian repeated in a low voice, then asked, "Did the Queen mention what signs there would be if another city-state went through an 'Elder Gods awakening' like Frostholm?"

"No," Duncan shook his head. "She couldn't confirm the mechanism of this 'awakening' either. Maybe the only way is to enter the Abyssal Deep Sea itself, and check the true state of the Abyssal Lord directly."

As soon as he finished, several pairs of eyes in the room turned at once toward Dog, who was hunched in a corner.

"Don't look at me!" Dog almost jumped up on the spot, its huge skull shaking back and forth. "It's not possible. I can't get anywhere near the Lord, and I definitely can't take people in there…"

"But you can open a 'passage' to the Abyssal Deep Sea, and you can even take Shirley through that passage to run," Duncan said, looking seriously at the only Abyssal demon present. "You also said Abyssal Hounds are a kind of demon born near the Lord. Your 'hometown' is right next to the Lord."

"That's a shallow passage. It only skims past the outermost edge of the Abyssal Deep Sea. It's meant for running away," Dog said. With everyone staring at it, it hesitated for two seconds, then had no choice but to spill these secrets—secrets that had been its and Shirley's trump card for staying alive for many years. "The Abyssal Deep Sea is far more complicated and strange than you think. It isn't one whole. The different 'zones' are not connected in a continuous way…

"From the shallow layer you can see the deep-layer zones, but without the right method, you wouldn't 'walk' to your destination even in ten thousand

years. There, ‘distance’ is an illusion, and ‘movement’ is only a false appearance…

“I have already been ‘banished’ from the Abyssal Deep Sea. I can’t explain the exact principle—maybe because I grew a ‘heart’. Many years ago, I already lost the ability to open a passage that leads to the Lord’s side. And besides that, I am now very unwelcome among the ‘locals’ over there. Even if I only skim past through the safe part of the shallow layer, I will draw countless demons to attack me…

“And even putting all that aside, I can’t just take any ‘person’ through. Abyssal demons can only take the person linked to them by a symbiotic pact through a passage—I can only take Shirley, not anyone else.”

Dog rattled off this long string of words, then carefully looked around at everyone—especially at Duncan’s reaction. It shrank its neck and added: “I’m not making excuses, Captain. You heard it yourself, there really are a lot of problems.”

Duncan was not angered by this long list of difficulties. He only thought seriously for a while, then asked, deep in thought: “So you mean the space of the Abyssal Deep Sea is discontinuous?”

“…You can probably think of it that way,” Dog said after thinking for a moment and nodding. “I can’t explain the details clearly—lately I’ve been studying Professor Brandall’s book, ‘Three Conjectures on Asymmetric Space-Time’. Maybe once I finish it, I can explain it to you better.”

Duncan did not pay much attention to Dog’s last sentence. He went on thinking, then asked another question: “But I remember you once mentioned that in the years when the Vanished was in full runaway state, it smashed through the entire Abyssal Deep Sea.”

Dog’s expression—though its expression was always rather abstract—changed at once. Its whole skeletal frame froze with a creak.

Duncan thought Dog simply did not remember, so he added a few details: “You said it fell from the Mortal Realm toward Subspace, then rose back from Subspace, oscillating between the realms and passing through them again and again. Each time, it smashed through the whole Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep Sea. In that process, didn’t it basically break through the ‘spatial fault lines’ inside the Abyssal Deep Sea?”

This time it was not only Dog whose expression turned abstract. Everyone in the cabin now wore a striking look—an eerie feeling of horror hung over them all, even over Lucretia on the other side of the scrying crystal.

“C-Captain!” Dog’s raspy voice finally came out, and every bone in its body was trembling. “Please don’t say something that scary… You’re not really planning to… to smash it again, are you…?”

“Father, please be careful,” even Lucretia, who had hardly spoken and still seemed rather distant, could not help breaking the silence. She stared at Duncan’s side of the scrying crystal with a tense face, as if afraid that her father would turn back into that cold, merciless terror of a “God” at any moment. “Letting the Vanished return to a runaway state to smash open the gate to the Abyssal Deep Sea is absolutely not a good idea. Even as a ‘research project’… that would be a bit too extreme.”

Duncan had not expected such a strong reaction from everyone after he voiced just one bold idea, so he shook his head: “Relax. I’m not about to run such an extreme ‘test’—I’ve always been a cautious man.”

Everyone clearly let out a breath of relief.

But then Duncan changed the subject and added: “Still, even from a cautious point of view, this ‘old event’ gives me an idea. Certain properties

of the Vanished can ignore the spatial fault lines inside the Abyssal Deep Sea. I will do some research based on that and see if I can open a door to that place while keeping things safe…”

Everyone’s hearts leaped back into their throats…

But at least this time no one raised as strong an objection as before. Only Morris and Lucretia, speaking as scholars, once again stressed the need for ‘safety’ and ‘caution’—judging from their attitude, they were clearly still worried that one day, on a whim, the captain might really steer the Vanished straight down into the Abyssal Deep Sea…

Luckily, Duncan moved on to the next topic soon after.

“Aside from the state of the Abyssal Lord, there is something else that concerns me more right now,” he said, rubbing his chin as he thought. “Those Enders—in strict terms, those ones who still have reason and act in a way completely opposite to ordinary cultists.”

He turned his head and looked at Tyrian.

“You once told Vanna that three Enders came to visit the Vanished and spoke with me through the whole night?”

Tyrian straightened at once, looking a bit awkward: “Yes, Father. Back then, I still could not confirm your… ‘state’, so I talked with Miss Vanna about some of your ‘old stories’.”

“It’s fine,” Duncan waved his hand. “I don’t remember much about those years, so it’s a good thing that you do.”

He calmly emphasized again that his “amnesia” came from the influence of Subspace, while also watching Tyrian’s and Lucretia’s expressions. Only then did he go on: “What I mean is, I have a feeling we will have to deal with those ‘sane Enders’ again sooner or later.”

Morris spoke up without thinking: “Why do you think so?”

“Because they seem dedicated to taking part in ‘historical events’ with far-reaching impact,” Duncan said slowly as he shifted in his seat. “And the disturbance caused by the Vanished… has been getting bigger and bigger.”

Chapter 497: Brewing Storm

Among all the cultists Duncan had met so far, the ones called Enders were the most mysterious and strange group of all.

Their numbers were far fewer than the believers of the Sun and the cultists of the Cult of Annihilation, but their ability to stir up trouble was unmatched. Their actions were bizarre, their goals a mystery. To this day, no one knew what kind of “organization” they had, how many of them there roughly were, or where they were hiding.

What concerned Duncan even more than their twisted way of acting were their own “traits”—they seemed to exist nonlinearly along the timeline, and every one of them was like that.

In this world, the Churches of the Four Gods and the Authorities of the various city-states grouped the Enders, the cult of the Sun, and the Cult of Annihilation together as the three major cults. But in Duncan’s view, the Preachers were so twisted and so out of step with the others that they ought to be taken out and put in a category of their own.

“From the information we have now, the Enders can be divided into two types. One type is the completely insane, extreme cultists. The other still has reason and even seems polite, like ‘sane scholars’,” Morris said from one side of the long table as he slowly cleaned his pipe and thought aloud. “The latter will actively approach people and try to give ‘mental guidance’ to the ones they choose. Judging by how often they show up, there seem to be far fewer of these ‘rational ones’ than of the mad ones.”

“In the heretic contact reports I know of, every recorded Ender was insane,” Vanna nodded. “That shows that those madmen make up the vast majority of these ‘preachers’. The rational ones are just rare exceptions.”

“They are, after all, a bunch of people tangled up with Subspace all day long—being mentally unstable is basically normal for them,” Dog said offhand, then quickly glanced up at Duncan. “Ah, Captain, I didn’t mean you…”

Duncan ignored Dog’s muttering. He only thought quietly, then suddenly said after a moment: “Whether mad or sane, these two kinds of Enders actually have one thing in common—they are all trying to meddle with ‘history’.”

On both sides of the long table, everyone fell into brief thought. Agatha, who had hardly spoken until now, looked up: “You mean the Ender who first approached the Queen of Frostholm was also acting for some specific ‘future’…?”

“Maybe we should try to look at history from the Enders’s ‘point of view’,” Duncan said, not in a hurry. “If we assume they really are a group of Nonlinear Existences, ‘time smugglers’ of a sort, then what does the ‘history’ we see look like to them?”

The cabin went quiet. After a short silence, Morris’s voice suddenly sounded: “…Everything has already happened, but everything can also not happen. The way the world goes can be adjusted. You only need to find the right ‘correction points’…”

“Exactly. The three Preachers who came to the Vanished a hundred years ago, the ‘mysterious scholar’ who contacted the Queen of Frostholm more than fifty years ago—their actions all greatly changed the later course of history. If we look only at how they ‘intervened in history’, the mad and the sane Enders actually behaved in the same way,” Duncan nodded. “Their

difference is that the mad Preachers seem to want to wipe out history completely, while the sane ones seem to want to ‘correct’ history toward some direction they’re hoping for…”

“Correcting history…” Vanna frowned deeply. “That is a dangerous phrase. The Flamebearers devote themselves to protecting our history from outside interference. They are the Church of the True Gods that deals with the Enders the most. And according to the teachings of ‘Everburning Ember Tarrigan’, history has its own strictness and purity. It must not be touched, must not be reshaped—for ‘history’, any kind of ‘correction’ is also a form of damage…”

“Then what if it is restoring history that has already been damaged back to its original state?” Duncan asked, then added, “Of course, I don’t mean the actions of the Enders. I’m just curious about the question itself.”

“…I’m sorry. That already involves the deeper, more complex parts of the Flamebearer Church’s doctrine,” Vanna said after thinking for a moment. She lowered her head with a hint of apology. “Among the Churches of the Four Gods, they act in the most secretive way, and their teachings are the hardest to understand. I know very little about them.”

“Is that so…” Duncan nodded slowly, still thinking, and his gaze moved along the edge of the long table—Agatha, Vanna, and Morris all came into view.

“…We’re still missing an expert on the Flamebearers,” he could not help sighing quietly.

Vanna’s and Morris’s expressions instantly became a bit odd.

Agatha did not change much—she was new here and did not react right away.

Duncan himself did not realize there was anything strange about what he had said—he had only spoken his thoughts out loud. The next second, he changed the subject: “Vanna, do you think the Flamebearers know about the existence of ‘sane Enders’?”

Vanna quickly pushed aside the slightly irreverent thought in her mind. After thinking a little, she answered honestly: “I’m not sure, but logically… I think they do know, or at least they should have noticed something.”

“The followers of ‘Tarrigan’ have spent centuries dealing with heretics and malevolent spirits that try to damage history,” Morris nodded as well. “The Flamebearers are skilled and sharp in this field. And based on what we know, those rational Enders have been active for at least a hundred years. Unless they really only appeared those two times in all that time, and every time they somehow completely slipped past the Flamebearers’ eyes, the Flamebearer Church must have noticed them. We just don’t know why… but the Flamebearers don’t seem to have taken any major action.”

“I’ll try to contact the Storm Cathedral and see if the Pope, Your Eminence, can find out anything from the Flamebearers,” Vanna said at once. “In many cases, cultists with reason are more destructive than simple madmen. Even though, for now, they seem friendly and even look like they have good intentions, I really can’t believe that a group of people who deal with Subspace all day long could have true reason and goodwill…”

Right after she spoke, Vanna suddenly felt that something was wrong. She froze for a second, then quickly turned to Duncan and added: “Ah, Captain, I didn’t mean you…”

Duncan’s face stayed expressionless.

He felt he had heard that line somewhere just now.

Then he waved his hand to show he did not mind. After thinking for a moment more, he finally spoke slowly: “We’re not only going to contact the Storm Cathedral, and the message we send will not only be about those Enders.”

Everyone present exchanged looks. Vanna was the first to react: “You want to send out a warning—like before?”

Duncan nodded with a serious expression.

“This might be even more dangerous than before. The ‘Elder Gods awakening’ incident in Frostholm could very well happen again in the short term. It might be that right now, beneath some city-state, a wrong Elder God replicant has already awakened. There is only one Queen of Frostholm, but there are many city-states on the Boundless Sea. To keep everyone from being caught unprepared, we at least have to let the upper levels of the Churches and the city-states know this crisis exists.”

As he spoke, he looked up at the people on both sides of the long table.

“Vanna, you contact the Storm Cathedral. Morris, you find a way to reach the Academy of Truth. Agatha, you should also have a channel to speak directly with the upper ranks of the Church of Death. You three pass on everything we discussed here today to your Churches as completely as you can: the true structure under the city-states, the situation related to the Abyssal Lord, and the information on the Enders.

“Then there is the Explorer Association. Lawrence, and Lucy as well, think about some reliable way to warn the Explorer Association—about the awakening of the Elder Gods—without causing panic.

“The captains on the Boundless Sea are a sharp, experienced group, and well informed. They are best at noticing if something strange shows up in some corner of this world.

“Tyrian, sort out the matters in Frostholm as soon as you can, then find a way, as governor, to contact the other city-states. Again, without causing panic, think of a way to make the other cities set up an early warning system for ‘Elder Gods awakening’ incidents.”

He said all this in one breath, then gathered his thoughts and went on, explaining and stressing his point: “Remember, tell the Churches as much of the full information as you can. In the supernatural field, they are at least somewhat ‘professional’ and have plenty of people.

“As for the city-states and the Explorer Association, you must weigh things very carefully, because that involves too many ordinary people. When you go back, think hard about how to pass on this ‘warning’ without revealing too much hidden knowledge. Remember, the goal is not to make them uncover the secrets of the Deep Sea, but to make them pay careful attention to any strange signs that might appear under the city-states and along the route.

“I’m done. Do you have anything to add?”

Duncan raised his eyes and quietly looked along both sides of the long table.

At that moment, everyone in the cabin—even Shirley and Alice—suddenly felt that something like a huge wave was building.

A storm strong enough to shake the whole world was taking shape along with the captain’s string of decisions and orders. In this eerie cabin lit by the ghostly green flame, in this hidden meeting with only a dozen people present, the course of the world already seemed faintly decided.

A feeling that he was taking part in history, even shaping history, slowly rose in Lawrence’s heart. He unconsciously felt his breathing quicken and his heart pound.

“This really is going to stir up a storm…”

The old captain, who had only just become a member of the Lost Home Fleet, could not help murmuring to himself.

“It’s not that we’re going to stir up a storm. The storm has already drawn near,” Agatha said softly, shaking her head beside him. “It’s just that no one ever noticed it—and now, we’re going to open the window.”

Chapter 498: Necessary Procedure

Duncan knew that the arrangements he made today were destined to throw the Boundless Sea into turmoil. This “warning” would shake everyone, not only because of what it warned about, but also because of where it came from.

The civilized world was about to feel a small “Vanished shock”.

“This is a big matter,” Tyrian broke the silence. “We don’t have to worry about the Church. When it comes to supernatural crises, they have always been sharp and professional. They will definitely treat this with enough seriousness. But the city-states are complicated. I really doubt that all of them can build an effective warning system.”

“Before that, think first about how many people will treat this ‘warning’ properly,” Lucretia’s voice came from the scrying crystal. “In this world, there are more ‘Doomsday’ warnings than anyone can count, and most of them come from mad cultists. Now the Vanished suddenly starts warning the entire world. To be honest… many people’s first reaction will probably be the same as when they run into those doomsday cultists, maybe even worse…”

On the other side of the table, Shirley muttered quietly: “Well, the reputation is what it is…”

“That’s their problem,” Duncan glanced at Shirley with a blank face and shook his head. “The Vanished’s ‘reputation’ is a good thing. Even if some people don’t believe the content of the warning, they will at least take the

‘warning’ itself seriously. Even if it’s only because they fear the Vanished, they will be cautious. That’s enough.”

“I will contact the Church as soon as possible,” Agatha nodded. Her hoarse yet gentle voice sounded. “I believe the Death Sanctuary will absolutely treat this warning from the Vanished with the highest priority.”

“Once Death, the Deep Sea, and Truth Academy receive the news, Flamebearer will definitely hear of it as well,” Vanna also nodded and added: “I will confirm this directly with His Holiness.”

“I haven’t written to Academy Ark in a long time. This is a good chance to catch up with some old friends,” Morris took off his blessed monocle and wiped it. “But I need to prepare some extra ointments and herbal powders for the ritual. It’s not easy to contact Academy Ark from the Boundless Sea.”

Hearing Morris’s words, Duncan suddenly thought of something.

“How is the matter I asked you to investigate last time?” He looked at the Grand Scholar. “That mark carried by the Ender, those Shattered Cross marks. Have you found where they came from?”

“I’m very sorry, there is no progress yet,” Morris looked a bit ashamed. “I’ve already written many letters to scholars I know well and contacted several universities we have good ties with, but none of them have any record related to those Shattered Cross marks. At the moment, we can only say they ‘might’ have appeared on some ruins from the ancient kingdom of Critt…”

“I see…” Duncan sounded a little disappointed, but he knew that, with so little information, investigating a mysterious symbol was like looking for a needle in the sea. He did not cling to it. He simply said: “Then keep an eye on it. If there is any progress, tell me right away.”

Morris lowered his head at once: “Yes, Captain.”

Duncan grunted in response, then paused to think, making sure he had not missed anything. After that, he let out a quiet breath and stood up from the long table, letting his gaze sweep over everyone present.

“Then that’s it for today’s gathering. We’ve settled the general course of action. If you have any questions later, you can ask me at any time.”

At the far end of the long table, Lawrence subconsciously let out a breath of relief.

The gathering was not as dark and frightening as he had imagined. It was not full of strange rituals or strict, bloody rules. Even so, just the fact that he was here “under Captain Duncan’s constant attention” made him feel a lot of pressure. As the “new recruit” here, he had been tense from head to toe. Now he could finally relax.

But he had only relaxed halfway when he noticed that the others around the table had no intention of getting up to leave. Instead, including the respected Grand Scholar Morris, most of them looked as if they were expecting the next part.

The gathering still had a process?

The thought had just crossed Lawrence’s mind when he heard Nina’s voice from across the table: “Ah, finally done talking. Time to eat, time to eat, I’m starving.”

“Big dinner today! Big dinner!” Shirley shouted happily. “It’s gathering day. We get good food!”

“The soup is still simmering in the pot. The timing is perfect,” Alice said as she stood up. “I’ll go push the serving cart over~”

Lawrence watched this scene in a daze, unable to figure out what was about to happen. He turned to look at Agatha, who sat closest to him, but saw the same puzzled look on her face.

Just then, Duncan's voice came from the head of the long table, clearing up Lawrence and Agatha's confusion: "We're done with business, so we share a meal. That's the rule on this ship."

Done with business… share a meal?

Lawrence listened in shock, wondering if he had heard wrong. But then he saw the living Doll actually pushing a large serving cart back into the cabin. The slightly worn cart creaked as it moved. Many containers on it were filled with steaming… food.

Lawrence stared, wide-eyed, as Alice carried the dishes to the table. He watched Shirley and Nina run back and forth, helping to set out plates and knives and forks. He smelled the aroma of food—fresh bread, vegetables and fruits, and meat.

It all seemed normal. These were foods he knew. Food Humans could eat.

But among all the aromas, the richest came from a pot of soup at the end of the long table.

It was a delicious fish soup. Inside, tender pieces of meat curled slightly, no longer recognizable as any particular species. Steam rose from the surface. On that gently trembling broth, those curled pieces of meat seemed to retain a trace of life. In the drifting steam, they trembled and twitched.

But when he looked closely, that trembling and twitching seemed like an illusion that had never happened.

Without realizing it, Lawrence stood up. His gaze fixed on the pot of fish soup. He could not tell what kind of fish it was, nor could he sense anything strange about this "food". Yet a strong instinct still pounded in his chest. It

was something built up over decades of roaming the Boundless Sea, something that let even an “ordinary person” without the gift of Spiritual Insight sense certain supernatural things—

This had once been extremely dangerous. The kind of horror that could kill people and send an ocean-going ship to its grave in the Deep Sea. It was…

“It’s fresh fish,” Duncan said with a smile, speaking to Lawrence and Agatha, who were attending the gathering for the first time. “I caught it today. I had to sail quite a way out from Frostholm’s main island to find it.”

Fish? “Fish” caught far from safe routes, far from the shelter of islands?

Lawrence’s mind went blank for a moment. A chilling guess flashed through his head. Not far away, Morris gave him a friendly nod and said: “It’s just what you’re thinking, Captain Lawrence. But relax. This is a necessary step in joining us. And you don’t have to worry. It’s harmless now. On this ship, it truly is food.”

Lawrence listened in a daze. By the time he came back to his senses, Alice had already set a bowl of steaming fish soup on the table in front of him.

But when she reached Agatha, Alice stopped, looking a bit confused.

“I can’t eat,” Agatha said, looking a little embarrassed. “This body is already a dead shell. I can’t enjoy food anymore.”

“It’s fine,” Duncan said generously, waving his hand. “We call it a ship rule, but really it’s no different from an ordinary get-together. If you can eat, eat a bit. If you can’t, just chat. That still helps people grow closer.”

As he spoke, he turned his head and glanced at the scrying crystal placed in front of Tyrian: “Lucy, don’t forget your dinner either.”

“I’m eating, I’m eating,” Lucretia answered at once. “Lunie brought me roasted apple pie and bacon pie!”

Duncan nodded, then smiled as he looked down both sides of the long table. He picked up the wineglass by his hand and, as the Master, raised it high:

“Then, to the days when we can gather like this—”

…

The faint dizziness slowly faded. The ghostly green flame at the edge of his vision dispersed into the air. Cool, fresh sea wind swept across the deck and brought a moment of sharp clarity to his mind.

The experience of attending the gathering aboard the Vanished still felt like a dream, a little unreal, lingering in his thoughts.

Lawrence shook his head to clear it further, then walked to the edge of the deck and looked out at the sea, already sinking into the veil of night.

The shadow of the Vanished, faintly glowing, still floated on the sea not far from the White Oak.

“…It really was like a dream.”

He had gathered on a mysterious ghost ship, spoken with all kinds of “people”, including a living Doll, a shard of the Sun, and demons from the Abyssal Deep. He had discussed secrets of Elder Gods and Doomsday in the depths of the Spirit Realm. Then, under the gaze and witness of Subspace Shadows, they had shared the flesh of a Spawn from the Deep Sea.

When the gathering ended, when wind from the Mortal Realm world once again brushed his face, when the tension and numbness in his mind slowly faded and his thoughts could work again with Human reason, when those light and strange impressions from the gathering scattered, Lawrence finally began to understand the true “nature” of what had just happened.

A realization came to him late, yet all at once. He could not even say what he felt in his heart.

A normal person should be frightened afterwards. He should feel afraid. At the very least, when he remembered the “fish” he had eaten, he should feel horror.

But he felt nothing.

Only a strange calm and sense of belonging soothed his restless heart.

[The fish… was really good…]

Chapter 499: Calm and Quiet Days

In Frostholm, in the domed office of the city-state's Governor, Tyrian stood in front of a mirror, carefully straightening the medals and sash on his chest.

His one-eyed face still looked cold and stern, even a little frightening. But the brand-new Governor's uniform and those shining medals turned that sternness, at least in part, into a trustworthy authority. At this moment, the city needed a Governor with that kind of authority.

Tyrian let out a quiet breath and turned his head to look at the other side of the domed office.

Two Undying sailors were hanging the new city-state flag on the wall. Beside the flag, a line of strong words was carved deep into the wall by the door, just as it had been half a century ago:

"Let as many people as possible survive"

Tyrian looked quietly at those words. After a long time, he gave a small nod and walked toward the large desk not far away. There was still a little time before the official event began. He could use it to go over the steps he would soon have to follow, or to calm his emotions.

The Complex Lens Array on the desk started to move on its own. Light shimmered on the surface of the scrying crystal at the center of the lenses. Lucretia's figure appeared in the glow, looking Tyrian up and down.

"This outfit suits you very well," the "Sea Witch" in a black dress said. "It goes nicely with the eyepatch."

Tyrian tugged at the button near his collar and gave his younger sister in the scrying crystal a sideways look: “You came just to make fun of me?”

“I’m seriously complimenting you,” Lucretia said with a straight face. “You haven’t taken such good care of your appearance in many years. That rough and scary Pirate look really didn’t suit you at all.”

“I might have to keep this image for a very long time, until there is a more suitable Governor, or Father has other plans,” Tyrian said, then paused. “One day, I’ll miss those free and easy days.”

“At least that day isn’t today,” Lucretia said with a faint smile. “So, how do you feel, about to swear the oath and become the Governor of a city-state? I heard you also have to ride in a carriage afterward, touring the streets to show yourself to the citizens?”

“The parade is to calm people’s hearts,” Tyrian said. “It lets them believe that order has been restored and that someone in the city’s upper ranks is still taking responsibility. I don’t like this part very much, but it is necessary. As for how it feels to become Governor…”

He stopped for a moment, then shook his head and went on: “I don’t feel much. The handover in the government hall and the building of the team have already been done. I’ve been working as Governor up to now. Today’s so-called ‘inauguration’ ritual is just a public ‘procedure’.”

“Is that so? Then I wish you a smooth procedure, big brother,” Lucretia laughed, using the old way she had called him many years ago when they were children. After a brief pause, her expression turned serious. “How are you doing with what Father told you to do?”

“I’ve drafted a few secret letters to send to other city-states, but the details still need work,” Tyrian said. “I have to deliver the warning and make them realize how serious the situation is, but I also need to avoid

misunderstandings and keep other city-states from overreacting. Honestly, this kind of paperwork is harder than taking a fleet to fight Deep Sea Spawn or other Pirates."

"If you ask me, you should just state things clearly and make them sound serious," Lucretia said lightly. "Anyone who can become a Governor is smart, and at least their staff should be. They know what to do. You're just giving them a reminder, not teaching them like a nanny how to build a 'warning system'. I'm already getting ready to contact the Explorer Association—ha, I wonder how they'll react."

"A warning from the Vanished Fleet to the entire civilized world," Tyrian said with a sigh. "The last time something like this happened was a century ago."

"…Yes. When Father first discovered that the Border Collapse phenomenon had appeared in the 'inner regions'," Lucretia said softly. "I still remember how the Cathedral's bells rang then. Every city-state's newspapers were discussing the warning from Great Adventurer Duncan Abnomar."

"So many years have passed, and once again he casts his gaze on the 'border' of this world," Tyrian said quietly. "History seems to have returned to its starting point. Maybe, in some sense, the Vanished never went astray at all. Its century in Subspace was just a voyage in some wider dimension we can't yet understand. Now it has returned, bringing the light of a new route, just like the lines the mad poet Pullman left behind: 'They once could sail straight in one direction, until they rounded the world's far side and, at an astounding angle, returned to the Mortal Realm'…"

Tyrian recited that famous absurd poem from history in a low voice, then slowly stood up from behind the desk. From outside the domed office, the faint sound of a band could already be heard. Footsteps were coming from

the corridor. The time had come. It was time for the city to meet its new Governor.

“Good luck, big brother—and don’t forget my Spirit Realm lens.”

“Don’t worry. I remembered it this time.”

…

A sharp, chilly wind blew through the sparse trees along the path, over the dark carved fence, past the silent gravestones and the empty corpse platforms on both sides of the path, and finally faded away in the depths of the cemetery.

Two figures were walking slowly along the cemetery path.

One of them was especially tall and broad-shouldered, wrapped in a pure black coat and a matching wide-brimmed hat. Every bit of visible skin outside his clothes was wrapped in layer upon layer of bandages. He looked frightening at a glance.

The other wore a simple Nun’s black dress. Her eyes were covered, and her long brown hair hung loose over her shoulders.

“I thought you would attend Governor Tyrian’s inauguration ritual, even in this avatar form,” Agatha walked at Duncan’s side and spoke in a low voice. “It wouldn’t be hard to arrange a proper seat for you.”

“I’m not showing my face. He’s in a good state right now. If I really showed up, he might get nervous instead,” Duncan said. “Later, when the motorcade passes by here, I’ll just greet him from afar.”

As he spoke, he lifted his head and looked along the rather empty cemetery path and at the bare corpse platforms on both sides.

“…I really do miss this place a bit. In my memory, this path used to be full of spirit coffins.”

“During this special period, we had to change the process of sending off the dead,” Agatha said quietly. “For now, bodies must be sent to the furnaces as soon as possible. The Silent Monks comfort them and bid them farewell right beside the fire. The cemetery has become quieter instead.”

Duncan grunted in reply. Just before they reached the end of the path, he suddenly stopped walking.

The simple warden’s hut appeared before them—and in front of the hut stood a special guest.

A twelve-year-old girl, wrapped in a thick white winter coat and wearing a furry hat, bustled around in front of the warden’s hut like a tightly wrapped snowball. She hugged a broom almost as tall as she was and worked hard to sweep the snow from the doorstep.

“Is that Annie?” Duncan tilted his head slightly and asked in a low voice.

“It’s her,” Agatha replied softly. “Except for the first few days of the lockdown, she’s come here every day at noon during her school break. The old warden is gone, and we haven’t assigned a new one yet. The cemetery is temporarily managed by the nearest Cathedral. There’s no harm in her being here, so the Cathedral has allowed her to come and go as she likes.”

“Do they also have your permission?”

“…Yes.”

The girl in front of the hut finally noticed movement on the path.

She turned her head and stared in surprise at the two figures who had appeared not far away. After a few seconds of staring, she tossed the broom aside and ran over happily.

“Gatekeeper Sister! And Uncle Duncan!”

Annie greeted the two familiar faces with joy. But as soon as she shouted, she suddenly remembered something. She quickly straightened up, looked at Agatha, and said: “Mother said I should call you ‘Your Excellency the Gatekeeper’ or ‘Archbishop’…”

“It’s fine. Just call me whatever you like,” Agatha laughed and reached out to press down Annie’s hat. “Are you cold?”

“I’m not cold,” Annie shook her head. Then she grabbed Agatha’s hand and pointed with her other hand at the little hut not far away. “Your hand is too cold. Come inside and warm up by the fire—I even made herbal tea!”

Agatha instinctively wanted to refuse, but she saw that Duncan had already stepped toward the hut. She froze for a moment in surprise, then could only follow helplessly.

Inside the tidy, simple warden’s hut, the fire in the stove burned hot. Wood cracked and popped in the flames. Steam rose from the samovar beside the stove, carrying the bitter fragrance of herbs.

Annie poured two cups of hot tea and pushed the warm cups into Duncan and Agatha’s hands: “These are for the Guardians from the Cathedral who come to inspect the grounds. They’ll be here later. Even if you don’t drink, you can at least warm your hands.”

Only now did the girl seem to realize that the “Gatekeeper Sister” in front of her was already a corpse.

Agatha did not mind. She thanked her softly and held the cup in both hands as it slowly grew hot.

“Is it warmer?” Annie asked again.

Cold. The whole world was cold. The teacup was cold, and so was the fire.

Agatha smiled gently and said: “Much warmer.”

Then she noticed that Duncan beside her kept glancing around the room from time to time.

“What are you looking at?” she asked in confusion.

“I think this is a good place to ‘settle down’,” Duncan pulled his gaze back and said to Agatha. “If it’s just for ‘settling’ one avatar form, that house on Oak Street is a bit of a waste.”

Agatha blinked, then slowly understood. Surprise appeared on her face: “You… you mean…”

“The Vanished will continue its voyage. The Avatar I leave here in the city also needs a place to stay,” Duncan said calmly. “You don’t need to worry about finding a new warden. This will save you a lot of work.”

Chapter 500: The One Who Set Sail

Annie looked a little dazed as she stared at the two “guests” in the small house. Her gaze shifted back and forth between Agatha and Duncan. After a long time, Annie finally reacted a little and said: “Ah, Uncle Duncan, are you going to be the warden of the cemetery here?”

“Maybe,” Duncan said, looking at Agatha, who was still in shock. “Is that not allowed? Does the cemetery warden have to be a retired Guardian?”

Agatha finally came back to her senses and spoke in a hurry: “No… Normally the cemetery wardens are retired Guardian veterans, but if I step in, I can of course arrange a position for you. That’s not the problem. The key is… do you really want to stay in this cemetery as its warden?”

“In Pland, I am still an antiques merchant,” Duncan said, his eyes full of amusement. “The Vanished will never stay in one place, but my avatar form will remain in the city-state. I need something to do. I can’t spend every day doing nothing, just drinking tea and reading the newspaper in that big house on Oak Street, can I?”

“I… never actually thought about that,” Agatha admitted, feeling a little embarrassed. “I never even considered what your ‘avatar form’ would need to do in daily life…”

“It’s normal. Most novels and films never mention what the protagonists do for work after the events end. In the Mortal Realm, you are now doing the work of two people by yourself, and Tyrian is buried in paperwork all day,”

Duncan laughed. “For me, steering a ghost ship that never docks, drifting on the Boundless Sea day after day, is also rather boring. Living a normal life in a city-state is my way of making sure I still feel like a ‘human’. You can think of it as…”

Agatha cut him off at once: “I’ll arrange it for you right away. You can ‘take office’ at the cemetery tomorrow.”

Duncan said: “…I hadn’t finished speaking yet.”

“I already heard the most important part,” Agatha said solemnly. “Don’t worry. Even if the Cathedral asks questions, I will make sure you can be the warden of this cemetery in peace.”

“…I feel like you may have read a bit too much into what I just said, but it’s not a big problem,” Duncan said, a little awkward. Then he really did start asking about the “job”: “What does a cemetery warden usually have to do?”

“There really isn’t much work,” Agatha explained. “A warden’s job is just to make sure the cemetery is not ‘disturbed’, to keep supernatural powers calm, and to register the living and the dead who go in and out. As for maintaining the cemetery facilities, the Cathedral nearby sends people to handle that. Given that Frostholm is now extremely safe even at night, I think… not only you, but all the cemetery wardens probably won’t have much to do anymore.”

When she said this, Agatha’s tone grew a little strange. Her eyes kept drifting toward Duncan from time to time. It was clear she was thinking about the link between Frostholm’s recent peaceful nights and the being standing before her.

And there were some words she did not say out loud—even if the city-state’s nights were still as dangerous as before, what would it matter? Now that the cemetery had welcomed a “warden” like this, there would probably

never again be incidents of restless supernatural powers. She guessed that even if something from Subspace crawled out of a coffin, this new warden would just slap it back in with one hand…

Either way, it was a good thing.

Duncan had no idea what was going through Agatha's mind, and he himself did not think too deeply about it. He really did just want to find something for this body to do. Thinking of the last will lingering in this body, and of the "bond" between himself and this cemetery, he had finally chosen to stay here and become the cemetery's new warden.

He would continue to cast his gaze over Frostholm from here, tending and watching over this city-state, just as he did in Pland.

The hot tea in his hand had already cooled.

Duncan set the teacup on the low table beside him, then stood up and quietly looked around the small room. The simple, plain furnishings came into view, as if they still held traces of the former owner.

On the wall by the door, an old hunting rifle hung quietly from an iron hook. It looked very worn, yet the bolt still shone, reflecting the firelight from the nearby stove.

Duncan looked at the old rifle for a moment, nodded slightly, and pushed the door open to step out of the house.

Lively, cheerful music came from some street outside the cemetery, mixed with the sound of fireworks being set off.

Annie slipped out of the door behind him. Listening to the commotion on the distant streets, she happily tugged at Duncan's coat: "The new governor's motorcade is about to pass through the cemetery ring!"

“Many people are still afraid of the new governor,” Duncan lowered his head, a smile at the corner of his eyes. “You don’t look scared at all.”

“I’m not afraid. Mother said the new governor is a hero who protects the city-state,” Annie lifted her face and squinted in the sunlight. “He’s very amazing, just like Dad.”

Duncan thought for a moment, then reached out and gently pressed down on the girl’s furry hat.

“Yes. He will be an excellent governor.”

…

Out on the Boundless Sea, Duncan crossed the aft deck and returned to the captain’s cabin.

Goathead was carefully holding the wheel. On the chart table, the thick mist floating across the surface of the large enchanted sea chart was slowly shifting and fading.

Duncan stood before the enchanted sea chart for a while, his gaze sweeping over the route near Frostholm that was gradually becoming clear. Then he stepped over to a corner of the room.

The Oval Scrying Mirror with its old, elegant frame still hung quietly on the wall of the captain’s cabin. It reflected the scene in the room, but for some reason, under the crossing sunlight and shadows, that reflection looked faint and hazy.

Duncan stepped forward, curled his finger, and lightly tapped the edge of the mirror.

In the next second, the surface of the seemingly ordinary mirror rippled with layer upon layer of hazy light, as if countless mists and motes of dust

were rising from the world inside the glass. Then, within that blur of light, a figure appeared.

Agatha—the Gatekeeper in the mirror—appeared before Duncan.

“Good day, Captain,” Agatha’s slightly magnetic voice came from the mirror. “I’m glad to see you.”

Duncan nodded and asked casually: “How do you feel? Are you getting used to it?”

“I feel… pretty good,” Agatha said slowly. “When I first ‘transferred’ onto the ship, the vast, empty world inside the mirrors made me a little nervous. But as I’ve grown used to it, that empty darkness has slowly faded… I also tried talking with Lady Martha. She taught me many skills and bits of knowledge about being a mirror world. They were all very useful.”

Hearing this, Duncan raised his eyebrows: “Oh? You can contact Martha directly from here?”

“The Black Oak is drifting in the reflections of the nearby sea. In the world of the mirror worlds, she and I are ‘neighbors’,” Agatha said with a smile. “It’s a very strange experience—the world inside the mirrors is not continuous, yet everything is connected. I can jump from one mirror to another, appear in many mirrors at the same time, or hide in the vast emptiness behind the glass… It may take many, many years before I fully understand it all.”

Duncan listened with great interest as this mirror world described those mirror laws that lay far beyond ordinary understanding. When she finished, he nodded lightly: “It sounds like you’re enjoying it. That’s good.”

Agatha paused, then sighed softly: “…Yes. It’s better than I imagined.”

The captain’s cabin fell silent for a while. After an unknown time, Duncan suddenly broke the silence: “I want to know what made you decide to leave

Frostholm and set out on a journey with the Vanished. This will be the longest voyage of your life. This ship may go to many places—distant city-states, sealed secret realms, the Spirit Realm, the Abyssal Deep, even Subspace…"

Agatha in the mirror fell into thought. She considered the question very seriously. After several minutes, she spoke slowly: "I think it was when 'we' descended together into that dark Deep Sea."

Duncan did not speak. He just watched the person in the mirror, waiting for her to go on.

Her voice came again from the mirror—

"I have all of Agatha's memories and feelings. In those memories, I was born in Frostholm. I grew up with my family and friends. I studied and trained and faced the Church's trials. There were those streets, those old clock towers, all those things that were worn and run-down yet still so familiar. All of it is in my mind, clear and deep, as if… I had lived it myself.

"But we both know that up until the day the mirror world invaded, the part of that life that truly belonged to 'me' was only three days long.

"So when my mind returned, when I came back to this world again in the form of a mirror world, I kept asking myself one question—am I Gatekeeper Agatha, or am I just a 'person' who inherited someone else's memories and was born into this world again?"

She stopped. As a mirror world, her eyes were bright, and right now those eyes were fixed on the captain outside the mirror with a serious gaze.

"You were right. A 'person' cannot live forever as someone else's shadow.

"Almost all the memories of my life came from another person. But even so, there are three days in those memories that belong to me alone.

“But if I stayed in Frostholm, those three days of ‘life’ would sooner or later be buried under the larger, deeper memories. I can’t cut off my connection to that city, and I cannot avoid my human weaknesses as a Mortal. I would be doomed to be a shadow—a shadow full of regret, trapped in memories. And as time went on… that regret would sooner or later turn into resentment and hatred.

“I can’t accept that possibility.

“But during that ‘Deep Dive’ I took with you, something you said to me… showed me a new possibility.”

Chapter 501: Before Leaving, One Last… What the Hell?

For Agatha, the “replica” born from the mirror world, her life was split into two clearly divided parts—

One part was warm, bright, and full, filled with all her love, hate, and attachment to this world, yet in essence it was just a lie that had been fabricated and fed into her mind.

The other part lasted only three short days, filled with pressure, exhaustion, pain, and finally a death that felt like release—yet that was the only memory that truly belonged to her.

And now, after going to the dead and then returning to the living world, the replica had a chance to keep moving forward. The problem before her was this: the first life was something she longed for, but she could never truly have it. After long years, all its regrets would turn into anger. The second life was real but thin, and such a pale, brief existence was not enough for her to live as a complete “person”.

Before this hard choice arrived, Captain Duncan had given her a warning. After thinking for a long time, she reached one conclusion: she had to leave Frostholm.

The dark, icy Deep Sea was terrifying. Yet the act of “diving down” itself let her discover for the first time that “life” could have another path, just as the captain had described to her inside the Submersible—

“We grope our way forward in endless darkness. Civilization itself is only a small, delicate, fragile skiff. Its lights shine on the water around it, and with our shallow Mortal wisdom we try to understand the shapes that appear in the dark and guess what the world looks like…

“Most people spend their whole lives curled up in the safe corner of the skiff. But someone has to stand at the bow and hold the lamp, someone has to look toward the distance. It is a road that must always move forward, because ‘the unknown’ is a one-way idea. So… maybe I can try it.”

Agatha in the mirror spoke calmly. At some point, the black clothes that marked her as a Gatekeeper had quietly changed into an outfit more like that of an adventurer at sea—a little like Martha’s style, but still bearing a few traces of the Church of Death. She raised a hand and took off the hat that marked her as clergy, letting her long hair fall freely, and the bandages wrapped around her body slowly faded away.

She lifted her head and gave Duncan a slight smile.

“A replica has no real past, but I can have a real future. Let those precious memories lie quietly in the past. That way, when I look back on them in the years to come, they will still be bright and warm, instead of stained by human weakness.

“Lady Martha helped me design these clothes. What do you think?”

Duncan looked at Agatha in the mirror for a long time, then nodded seriously: “They suit you very well.”

“Do you think I should change my name?” Agatha asked again. “If I plan to walk a completely new path from now on, should I start by changing my name too?”

This time Duncan stayed silent for a long while. After thinking for a long time, he still shook his head: “No need. I think it’s good for you to remain

Agatha.”

“Why?”

“Because I’m used to calling you that. Changing it would be inconvenient,” Duncan answered offhand. “I can tell you ‘two’ apart anyway, and you can tell each other apart too.”

Agatha in the mirror gave Duncan a long look. “…That doesn’t sound like your real answer, but it’s enough to convince me. I happen to like this name too—let’s treat it as the last bit of remembrance I leave for my ‘past’.”

Duncan nodded: “Mm. I’m glad you think that way.”

“Have you already settled everything in the city-state?” Agatha asked again. “Do you really plan to be a ‘cemetery warden’ in Frostholm from now on?”

Duncan raised his eyebrows: “What’s wrong with that position?”

“There’s nothing bad about it… It’s just that when I think about ‘Captain Duncan’, who in many people’s eyes is like the shadows of Subspace, acting as the warden of a cemetery inside the city-state, it feels very strange,” Agatha said frankly. “But as long as you’re willing, it’s of course a good thing—there probably won’t be any place safer than that cemetery from now on.”

“I think it’s great. I still run an antique shop in Pland. Keeping some activity in civilized society is good for my state of mind,” Duncan said with a smile. “Besides, keeping an avatar form living in a city-state costs money. Working as a warden in the cemetery at least gives me an inco—”

Duncan suddenly stopped.

He slowly lifted his head and looked at the “Gatekeeper” in the mirror. In a very serious tone, he asked: “Will the Cathedral pay this ‘new warden’ a salary?”

Only then did Agatha react: “You still need a salary?!”

“You don’t pay salaries?!”

“Ah, under normal circumstances of course we do. The cemetery warden’s pay is sent directly by the Cathedral…” Agatha said, her expression growing strange. “But a shadow from Subspace running off to be a warden in a cemetery is not a normal circumstance. I strongly suggest you go to the Cathedral and talk seriously about this with the other Agatha. Based on what I know about ‘myself’, if you don’t bring it up, she absolutely won’t think of it—or rather, she wouldn’t dare to.”

Duncan said: “…Is it really that absurd?”

“The string of numbers you wrote at the end of your denunciation letter almost drove a room full of cryptographers and mathematicians mad. Later, when the Cathedral transferred money to your bank account, they even set up a special covert team just to monitor changes in the Spirit Realm. When you deal with ordinary people as a ‘shadow from Subspace’, please think about the worldview of most normal humans.”

Duncan’s mouth twitched. He rubbed his forehead. “…All right. I understand.”

Agatha seemed to breathe a little easier, then asked curiously: “Now that the situation in Frostholm is settled, what are your plans next?”

“I plan to return to the Central Seas. Using some archaeological notes Morris gave me, I’ll follow the routes and visit those ancient ruins and strange sea regions that interest me. If possible, I want to approach, or even enter, some areas that are listed as ‘Visions’, to explore and learn as much about this world as I can,” Duncan clearly had long since made his plans, and he spoke of his journey with great enthusiasm. “Along the way I’ll keep in touch with the civilized world, and see how the major Churches react to

my ‘warning’. If they’re interested, I don’t mind dealing with those mysterious Cathedral ark-ships again…”

“It sounds like an adventure worth longing for,” Agatha said, her tone full of joy and expectation. “It will be full of danger, but worth the trip. It seems my decision was right… Are we setting sail now, or do we need more preparation?”

“No hurry. We have to settle matters with the White Oak first, and I also need to let Tyrian know,” Duncan said with a laugh. “By now he should be back in his domed office. I’ll just go and ‘say hello’ to him.”

“Understood. Then I won’t disturb you.” Agatha lowered her head, and her figure slowly faded from the mirror.

At the same time, in the domed office of Frostholm’s Government Hall, Tyrian had already sent off the last department representative. He had taken off the gorgeous but uncomfortable coat he wore for ritual occasions, changed back into his everyday clothes, and sat behind his desk, letting out a small sigh of relief.

Next, he would have a short break—to prepare for the rest of the day’s work.

Running a city was far harder than commanding a fleet, especially a city that was a mess in every corner. Even on his swearing-in day, he had no chance to stop working. This morning’s ceremony had been “forced” into his normal schedule, and he would have to catch up with everything he missed in the afternoon and evening.

Besides, Frostholm’s affairs were far from the only thing he had to handle.

The vast “enterprises” that the Sea Mist Fleet had built over the past fifty years, his own complex and delicate ties with other city-states, the balance

of power in the Frost Sea, and his relationship with the “Family”… put together, these tasks were no easier than the job of governor.

Tyrian let out a long sigh, opened a locked drawer beside his desk, and took out a stack of files and documents—archives related to the Sea Mist Fleet, shared information from the Radiant Star, and private letters from other city-states.

In other words, his “break” meant he could put aside his duties as governor for a while, so he could work on another pile of tasks just as hard as being governor.

Tyrian glanced over the pile and couldn’t help raising a hand to scratch his hair.

For some reason, First Mate Aiden’s smooth bald head suddenly appeared in his mind.

The dreadful thought that came with that image sent a chill through the new governor, and he quickly stopped scratching his hair.

“Aiden shaved his head himself back then. Aiden shaved it himself… He’s regretted it for a whole century already…”

Tyrian muttered under his breath, as if trying to shift the pressure he felt facing the pile before him. Just then, a faint crackling sound suddenly came from nearby, cutting off his muttering.

His heart jolted without thinking, but he quickly calmed down again and looked up calmly at the mirror on the nearby wall.

He was used to this…

Duncan’s figure appeared in the glass.

“Son, I came to say hello—did everything go smoothly?”

“Everything went smoothly, Father,” Tyrian stood up, carefully meeting his father’s gaze, though he already felt much more relaxed than usual. “Do you have any instructions for me?”

“Nothing much. I’m just getting ready to lea—”

Duncan suddenly stopped.

Tyrian looked at his father in the mirror in confusion, only to see that Duncan was staring fixedly at… the desk beside him, with an especially strange expression.

There was even a hint of shock on his face.

The shock in that expression made Tyrian’s heart tighten. He hurriedly followed his father’s gaze, only to see a single sheet of paper that had slipped from the pile of documents. It was something Lucretia had sent him from the Radiant Star.

It was a piece of “shared academic material”.

Duncan’s unusually serious voice came from the mirror: “Tyrian, what is that? Bring it closer and let me see!”

“Ah… all right,” Tyrian answered in a rush. He quickly picked up the paper and walked to the mirror, holding the image on it up for his father. “Is there something wrong with it?”

“…Where did this pattern come from?”

“Lucretia sent it,” Tyrian answered at once, sounding a little nervous and guilty. “I didn’t mention it before, but she’s been studying something that fell from the sky lately…”

But Duncan did not speak. He just stared hard at the sheet of paper. After a long time, he finally broke the silence in a voice that sounded like talking in a dream: “…the Moon?”

Chapter 502: Heading South

A strange word he had never heard before reached his ears. Its mysterious, harsh sound did not even seem to belong to any language Tyrian knew.

He lowered his head in shock and glanced at the file, at the precise drawing of the stone sphere on it. After a long moment he finally looked up and asked: “Father, what did you just say? ‘The Moon’… is that the name of this thing? Do you know this mysterious sphere?!”

Duncan, however, seemed not to hear him. He still stared at the image on the paper, the image of the Moon that looked so familiar to him. Only after Tyrian repeated his question twice did Duncan suddenly come back to himself. He looked at Tyrian and quickly asked: “You just mentioned Lucretia. What exactly happened?”

“Um… this is information she sent from the Radiant Star,” Tyrian said after a pause. Father’s strange reaction made him uneasy, but under that oppressive, almost gaze he still poured out everything he knew: “Some time ago, a mysterious glowing object fell from the border region and happened to be found by Lucretia. She has been studying it all this time. This strange sphere is the ‘core’ of that fallen relic…”

Tyrian slowly told the whole story from beginning to end. He spoke of how the scholars in Lightwind Harbor had judged that the fallen relic came from Visions 001, and of all the progress they had made so far in their study of the stone sphere, as well as all the problems they had run into.

While he spoke, Duncan did not interrupt even once. Duncan only listened in a strange, heavy silence that made Tyrian feel even more pressure, as if he meant to carve every sentence deep into his mind and take every word apart, grind it down, and dissect it a thousand times over.

After more than ten minutes, the domed office fell quiet again.

Duncan stayed silent for a long time. At last, before the air itself seemed to grow solid, he let out a quiet breath and asked: “Why did you not tell me about this before?”

“…Lucretia wanted to wait until her research had made some progress before contacting you. And more importantly… at that time we were in the middle of the Frostholm crisis.”

After a while, Duncan felt his pounding heart slowly calm down. As he listened to Tyrian, he finally gave a small nod and asked: “This thing is in Lightwind Harbor now, is it not?”

“Uh… yes,” Tyrian said at once, nodding. His lips felt dry, and he watched Father’s expression with growing tension. After hesitating several times, he could not help asking again: “Do you know this mysterious sphere?”

“…It is called the Moon. At least, that is what it looks like. But the Moon I know does not have a diameter of ten meters, and it could never float on the sea and be dragged back to a city-state with steel cables by a ship,” Duncan said slowly. “Perhaps it is only some man-made object that copied its shape. Perhaps it is only something the ancient kingdom of Critt…”

He broke off halfway. The sense of deep contradiction and the tangled thoughts in his mind clashed so hard that none of his guesses could explain this matter. No matter what, one thing was beyond doubt: in the picture on the document in Tyrian’s hand, that was indeed the Moon. And no matter whether the stone sphere Lucretia had picked up at sea was the true Moon,

or only an “artificial flying object” made by the ancient Critt kingdom to imitate the Moon, one question still remained:

Why would the image of the Moon he knew so well appear here? Why would it appear in this eerie, twisted “other world”?

Lost in his thoughts, he frowned and looked at Tyrian: “You said just now that the scholars in Lightwind Harbor have already confirmed that the mysterious glowing glowing orb fell off the rune ring of Visions 001?”

“Yes. They have already confirmed with their own eyes the shape of the gap on the Sun’s rune ring,” Tyrian said. Then another question came to him, and he added: “You said it is called ‘the Moon’… then what exactly is the Moon?”

“The Moon…” Duncan hesitated. He suddenly found that he did not have the right words to explain such a simple name to Tyrian. After thinking for a long time, he could only say: “…It is a planet.”

When Tyrian heard this, the confusion on his face only grew. He asked: “What is a planet?”

Duncan fell silent.

After a very long time, he finally heard Tyrian’s voice again: “Is this a forbidden question? Am I asking too much?”

“No, it is not forbidden. It… should be the simplest question of all, yet I have no way to explain it to you,” Duncan said with a slight shake of his head. He looked at the opposite side of the mirror with a complicated expression and said: “I am sorry, Tyrian. The answer to this question is simple, but helping you understand it is the hardest part.”

Tyrian froze a little.

He looked at Father in the mirror, his expression complicated and apologetic. For a moment, Tyrian suddenly felt that this scene had happened once, long, long ago, somewhere deep in a distant, hazy memory, on some faded afternoon…

On that day, he and Lucretia had stood for the last time on the deck of the Vanished and had asked their father, who had decided to cross the border, what exactly lay beyond the border.

Back then, Father's reaction had been exactly the same as now.

It was the look of someone who knew an extremely simple truth, yet did not know how to explain it to others.

Just then, Duncan's voice came suddenly from the mirror and cut off Tyrian's sinking memories: "I have changed my plan. Next, the Vanished will head for Lightwind Harbor."

It was within his expectations. The moment Father had reacted like that to the sphere called the Moon, Tyrian had known things would develop this way.

"I understand. I will explain the situation to Lucretia."

…

Nina looked worriedly at Duncan, who was standing at the far edge of the deck and gazing out at the sea. Alice walked past her, and Nina pulled her to a stop.

"Uncle Duncan, what is going on?" Nina asked in a low voice. "He has been staring into the distance this whole time. He looks like he has a lot on his mind…"

"I do not know," Alice said, glancing up at him and shaking her head in confusion. "He has been like that since he came out of the captain's cabin.

He said he had to think about some things…”

“Think about some things?” Nina blinked, puzzled. “Did something happen?”

Alice thought carefully for a moment, then nodded and said: “He contacted Tyrian, but I do not know what they talked about.”

“Mr. Tyrian?” Nina was stunned. Then her imagination began to run wild, and her expression slowly turned odd. She asked: “Is it because Mr. Tyrian still has not gotten married?”

Alice looked utterly lost and asked: “Huh? What do you mean?”

Nina thought for a moment, then began to explain very seriously: “I heard it from Mr. Morris. He often worries about Miss Heidi’s marriage. But Mr. Tyrian is even older than Miss Heidi. So by the same logic, the captain must be even more worried about this…”

Alice was completely taken in. She nodded in a daze and said: “So that is how it is!”

Just as she finished speaking, Duncan’s voice suddenly came from beside them: “That is enough, you two. Nina, you must not tease Alice like that. She will take it seriously.”

“Wah!” Nina jumped in fright. Only then did she notice that Uncle Duncan had somehow come up beside her. She quickly drew back her neck and stood up straight like a good girl.

Alice scratched her hair in confusion and looked at Nina with a puzzled face, asking: “Were you teasing me just now?”

“…In any case, do not take what she just said seriously,” Duncan said helplessly. Then his gaze fell on Nina. “Do not worry. Nothing bad has happened.”

Nina stuck out her tongue, but soon her face turned worried again. She asked: “Uncle Duncan, what exactly happened? You rarely look so troubled…”

For a moment Duncan did not know how to answer this young lady’s question. What appeared in his mind was still that drawing he had seen in Tyrian’s office and the strange thing Lucretia had “picked up” at sea.

The Moon…

He raised his hand and rubbed his aching brow. But in the next second, his movement stopped, and he turned instead to stare fixedly at the girl in front of him.

Nina stood there obediently, a slightly worried look on her face.

Duncan looked at her, at this quiet, gentle, well-behaved little solar prominence. Beneath that shell of a human maiden, he seemed to see directly the bright arc left behind after a star shattered, and the blazing plasma flow that had once erupted in the void of space…

The little solar prominence tilted her head, reached out, and gently touched Duncan’s tightly furrowed brow, as if she wanted to smooth out those deep lines. She asked: “Uncle Duncan, are you really all right?”

Duncan did not speak. He only took Nina’s hand and pressed it to his forehead, then slowly let out a breath.

Once again he understood a few more things. Behind the heavy Veil, this world had once more shown him a corner of the “truth”. Yet this small piece of truth was something he could not share with anyone.

“Do not worry, Nina. Everything is fine,” he said slowly, gradually returning to his usual self. “I have run into some hard questions, but right now it is hard to explain them to you. When I solve them, I will explain everything to you properly.”

Nina listened in a daze, then nodded hard and said: “Mm.”

“Good. Then go back to the cabin first. It is time for us to set out. But before we depart, we need to detour to the Sea Mist Fleet’s base. We have to take something along for Tyrian…”

…

In the domed office of the governor of the Frostholm city-state.

With a faint humming sound, the scrying crystal slowly lit up. In its dim light, the figure of the Sea Witch gradually became clear.

“Brother?” Lucretia looked over with curiosity. “Are you done with everything over there? Did it all go well?”

“If you mean the appointment ritual, it ended this morning. Everything went well,” Tyrian said. His expression gradually turned complicated. “But I am contacting you for something else.”

Lucretia frowned and asked: “Something else?”

“Two things,” Tyrian said after a short hesitation, choosing his words carefully. “First, I have prepared the Spirit Realm lens you wanted. I used legal city channels to get you the best and most precise lens array device available at the moment.”

In the scrying crystal, Lucretia’s face lit up with joy at once. She said: “Ah, that is wonderful! Brother, you really are reliable! And what is the second thing?”

“…The second thing. Guess who is going to deliver the lens to you?”

“One of your transport ships?”

Tyrian did not answer.

Lucretia’s expression slowly changed. She said: “…It is one of your transport ships, right?”

Tyrian still did not answer.

Lucretia finally reacted.

“…Dad?”

“Yes.”

Chapter 503: The Day We Go Home

Lawrence stepped onto the bridge. First Mate Gus came up at once to meet him. Many crew members stood behind the first mate, looking at their captain with a hint of expectation.

Lawrence's gaze swept over these subordinates and friends who had followed him for so many years. After a long moment, he took a gentle breath and smiled: "We can go home. We set out now."

The First Mate's expression visibly relaxed, but he still could not help asking: "Then… what about the Vanished?"

"The Vanished will be taking another journey," Lawrence said with a slight nod, speaking to everyone. "Captain Duncan will head south to do something more important. He has ordered the White Oak to return to the normal routes of the civilized world according to our original sailing plan. According to that plan, we will first go to Cold Harbor for supplies and to fill our purchase orders, and then we will return to Pland."

"And after that?" First Mate Gus listened to the captain's words, but he still wore an uneasy expression. Clearly, just like everyone else on the ship, this Frostholm journey had been too unexpected and too long for him. Now that news of going home had come, he still could not believe that everything would simply go back to the way it used to be. "We…"

"We will still make our living on this sea. The White Oak has already gained passage rights, and the routes of the civilized world will stay open to

us. The only change is that, from now on, Captain Duncan will forever keep his gaze upon all of us," Lawrence said calmly. "When the Vanished sends an order, as a part of that fleet we will answer. But at least not now. Sailors, for now we can go home."

The bridge stayed quiet for more than ten seconds. Then someone finally began to clap. Gradually, more people joined in, and after that came a cheer that had been delayed for a very long time.

The news that they could go home spread across the whole ship in an instant and reached the ears of every sailor.

This long, unexpected journey had finally come to an end. This frightening and bizarre adventure would be carved deep into the memory of every person. The joy of going home washed away many worries about the future. A new Boiling Gold catalyst was fed into the steam core. The machinery bay began to roar. The whistle echoed over the boundless sea, as if the whole ship itself was cheering for the homeward voyage to come.

Lawrence walked to the edge of the foredeck and quietly gazed at the distant, rolling sea. The endless water had no clear point of reference and could almost give a person the illusion that the ship was still standing still. But the way the waves rose and fell and the sea wind blowing against his face told him that the White Oak had already set out.

He lowered his head and looked down past the side of the ship. Under the rolling surface of the sea, he saw the shadow of the Black Oak reflected like a dark cloud. At the bow of that ship, shrouded in darkness, the few sparse lights looked faint and hazy.

Martha's voice came from the pocket mirror at his chest: "Everyone is very happy. It seems that once the day of going home comes, their familiar life will return as well. But you should remind them that not everything will go back to the way it was. We have established a link with the Vanished. No

matter how much freedom that Captain Duncan has given us, this link with Subspace is bound to change many things… We should prepare for this curse and blessing.”

Lawrence was silent for a moment, then spoke softly: “You mean changes like those on the Radiant Star or the Sea Mist?”

“They will no longer grow old and die, but they will slowly drift away from the realm of the living. This ship will slowly undergo a transformation into a living thing. Some of its parts will suddenly seem to learn to think and will begin to move on their own. The very existence of the Black Oak, that ‘strange reflection’, will cause the White Oak to gradually gather all kinds of frightening and horrifying rumors and tales. Very soon, people will fear this newly born ‘ship of the curse’. And the passes issued by the Church will not solve that kind of problem…”

Martha spoke slowly and calmly. It sounded less like she was predicting Lawrence’s future and more like she was describing a past that had already happened. In her vast and tangled cluster of memories, she was tracing out the fate that the White Oak would surely face next.

But Lawrence only listened quietly. Only when Martha fell silent did he speak in a low voice: “Perhaps your prediction is right, and all those changes will slowly come. But at least not today. Today is the youngsters’ day to go home.

“They will return to the warm city of Pland before the year ends. They will embrace their family and friends and tell them about this incredible adventure as humans. And I will do everything I can to keep the White Oak active on all the busy routes, to make contact with the Church, with the Explorer Association, and with the city-state trade fleets. It is not only to carry out Captain Duncan’s orders, but also to make this ship a respected symbol before it becomes a thing of fear, a ship of the curse.”

The pocket mirror gave no reply.

But Lawrence felt a small gust of wind rise at his side. In a sudden patch of thin mist, a hazy shadow stepped out of the fog and gently embraced him from behind.

The touch was so faint and light it felt like a dream.

“Old man…”

“What is it?”

“So handsome I could die!”

…

Heavy, lead-like clouds of chaos covered the sky. Murky, dim light took the place of the bright, warm sunlight from before. A hazy mist spread over all the sea that the eye could see. On the surface of the water under that mist, black strands of shadow, as fine as hair, were quickly gathering, until at last they turned the whole sea into a field of pitch black.

The world became a strange illusion without color. On this black sea, the Vanished raised her spirit form sails. An invisible “wind” filled the canvas and drove the ship forward, letting it cut across the sea at a speed far beyond anything in the Mortal Realm.

On the platform at the stern of the Vanished, Duncan held the wheel himself. Goathead’s voice sounded in his mind: “We have safely sunk into the Spirit Realm. The Vanished is now sailing steadily in the Shallow Layer.”

Duncan grunted in reply, then turned his head and nodded to Nina, who was standing not far away and watching him steer with curiosity: “We have already sunk safely into the Spirit Realm.”

Nina nodded half in understanding and half in confusion. To her, steering a ship, and especially a sailing ship from a century ago, was something completely beyond her.

On the other side, Vanna could not help covering her forehead when she heard Duncan's words: "Uh, no matter how many times I hear it, it still feels wrong to put the words 'safe' and 'Spirit Realm' together. I still cannot believe that 'safely sinking into the Spirit Realm' is a phrase that can really exist in this world…"

Duncan only laughed when he heard this: "It takes some skill. But in Spirit Realm mode, we can sail at very high speed and do not need to worry about hitting most of the obstacles that exist in the Mortal Realm. After all, it is a very long journey from Frostholm to Lightwind Harbor."

"Lightwind Harbor… I have only seen that place in books," Nina said, her eyes shining with a little longing. "The books say it is a city-state built by elves and also one of the most important 'parishes' of the Truth Academy, second only to Morka. I heard they have the most advanced Sorting Engines and steam cores in the world there. Their mechanical craft and mathematics are very developed…"

"What the books say is true. But books often leave out one point: Lightwind Harbor is ahead not only in technology. It is also one of the important bases of the Explorer Association," Morris said to Nina with a smile. "Because the whole city-state lies close to the edge of civilization, countless pioneering fleets and explorers use Lightwind Harbor as a supply point and a hub for exchanging information. And those explorers, coming and going from all over the civilized world, bring all kinds of food with them. So Lightwind Harbor has also earned the name of a city of gourmet food…"

Nina listened with full curiosity and a thirst for knowledge to all this information that she could not find in books. At the end, her eyes suddenly

lit up and she asked: “Do they have sweet pancakes there too?”

“They should,” Morris said after thinking for a moment and nodding. “Commerce in Pland is very developed. Many merchants have opened routes from the Central Seas to the south. The foods of Pland will naturally spread there as well.”

Nina brightened up. She climbed onto a large wooden barrel next to Duncan, sat on it, and began to swing her legs over the edge: “That is great… Good food and the most cutting-edge machines. I am starting to look forward to it…”

Duncan glanced at Nina, who was rocking on the barrel, then at the deck around it. A few ropes on the open deck between the wheel and the barrel were trembling slightly, looking both troubled and humble.

Clearly, these ropes thought that this “crew member” Nina was far too close to the wheel at the moment. But they also feared the light of the Sun.

After all, that was a six-thousand-degree giant fireball.

“Stop rocking on that barrel, or you will fall,” Duncan said to Nina with a shake of his head. “Also, do not stay so close to the wheel. It is not safe.”

Nina reacted at once, let out a quick “Oh”, jumped down to the deck, and backed away to a safe distance.

The ropes near the wheel relaxed. They were safe now.

Nina was quiet for only a short while before another thought suddenly came to her.

“When we get there, we are going to meet that Lady Lucretia, right?” She leaned against the rail at the edge of the helm platform and blinked at Duncan, her tone a little nervous. “Is she easy to get along with?”

“…She should be fine,” Duncan said, his expression a bit hard to describe. When he tried to look at this question from Nina’s point of view, that feeling only grew stronger. “Lucretia is a scholar who is obsessed with research. Other than that, she does not seem hard to talk to. She has always been like that in front of me. But I truly do not know what she is like in her daily life.”

“To be honest, I am a little nervous,” Nina said, sticking out her tongue. “I heard people call her the ‘Sea Witch’. Captain Lawrence said she is a cold and bad-tempered witch and that she will curse people who disturb her research. Many famous adventurers are very afraid of her…”

Duncan held the wheel with one hand and turned his head to glance at Nina.

“Tyrian is also a Pirate Lord who makes people tremble at the sound of his name. Do you not think he is quite polite when he is in front of you?”

“…That is true.”

Chapter 504: Unstable Tendency

Most of the time, Nina did not really understand how powerful she was, or how much her power scared ordinary supernatural people. This did help her keep the mindset that she still belonged to humans, but it also definitely had bad effects.

After all, no matter where you slapped down a six-thousand-degree “pancake”, it would always be an earth-shattering event.

Fortunately, Duncan had paid attention to this problem from the very beginning. He often gave Nina mental guidance and reminders. He helped this young lady understand the danger of her own power, and he found ways to help her take hold of the might of the Sun step by step. At the very least, Nina had now slowly grown used to and accepted one fact:

For the Nina of today, this world was a delicate yet fragile paper house. If she was not careful, it would burst into raging flames. She had to control her breathing and her gaze with great care, so that everything would not turn to ash.

Now, it seemed that Nina’s understanding and control of her power had been successful. Except for a few extremely rare and not very harmful runaway state incidents, she had never burned anything by mistake. On the other hand, she still kept her “understanding” of herself as an ordinary person. Even after realizing how strong she was, her mindset had not turned arrogant or dangerous.

In Duncan’s view, this was very good.

The pitch-black sea slowly rose and fell in his sight. There was no clear line between the chaotic sky and the water. The ghost fire that surrounded the Vanished lit up the nearby waves. In the shifting light and shadow, strange and suspicious shapes sometimes flashed through the air or the sea and vanished again—

They were the “natives” of the Spirit Realm. These dim, chaotic beings were drawn to the intruder that was the Vanished. But whenever they gathered even a little, the spirit form flames burned them, and they scattered and fled in all directions.

Nina ran to the edge of the aft deck. She sat directly on the deck, letting her legs dangle and swing outside the railing, and watched this “sea” that looked strange and interesting in her eyes with great curiosity.

Duncan reminded Nina to be careful and not fall off the deck. Then he turned his attention back to the helm. After a while, a question suddenly came to his mind.

He turned his head and called: “Vanna.”

He glanced at Vanna, the Inquisitor, who was standing at the edge of the raised platform, looking out over the sea. “I suddenly have a question,” he said, “about the storm Goddess.”

Vanna turned at once, her face serious: “Please, ask.”

“The storm Goddess Gamona is the guardian of the sea, right?” Duncan said. “The entire Boundless Sea is under her protection. Then what about the sea of the Spirit Realm?”

The serious look on Vanna’s face instantly turned into shock. Then came more than ten seconds of awkwardness and deep thought. After a long time, she hesitated and shook her head, and spoke with some guilt: “I am sorry. I have never thought about that question…”

After she spoke, she began to reflect on herself: “It seems my study of the path of faith is still too shallow. I spend all day in prayer, yet I never really think about the details behind the scriptures…”

“It is normal that the scriptures do not mention such details,” Morris said casually from the side. “From the founding of the Deep Sea Church until now, there has simply never been a case of mortals moving freely deep inside the Spirit Realm. Doctrine is a tool used to explain the gods’ Truth to mortals. It only represents the known parts of that Truth, not all of it…”

“Then where did the very first ‘doctrines’ come from?” Duncan asked again. “In the early days when the city-states were first built and the faith in the Four Gods had just appeared, who wrote the first doctrine and used it to explain how the world worked? Was it the first mortal preachers, or those four deities themselves?”

This time, Morris fell into thought.

Duncan went on: “According to how the Four Gods Church now explains the scriptures, doctrine can only come from the gods, right?”

“Yes…” Morris nodded. He seemed to have quickly ordered his thoughts and answered Duncan’s question. “Doctrine is a partial expression of the Truth. Its source lies with the gods. According to the more accepted view, the earliest prophets of the Critt dynasty received ‘enlightenment’ from the gods. The gods’ thoughts entered their minds, and they naturally wrote down the first teachings during their awakening.

“After that came several hundred years of the ‘Age of Truth’s Self-revelation’ and the ‘Age of Recorded revelations’. Generation after generation of prophets received enlightenment and wrote down what they learned. In the end, this formed the current doctrines and scriptures of the Four Gods…”

Duncan did not speak for a while. He only thought very seriously. After a long time, he broke the silence again: “Do such enlightened prophets, who can now write new doctrine and Truth, still appear?”

Morris and Vanna looked at each other.

“As far as I know, no,” Morris said, shaking his head. “Saints can use the Listening rite to hear the gods’ voices, but it is usually only vague hints or warnings. As for those ‘prophets’ in the histories who could talk with God at length… there has not been one since the end of the Dark Age.

“As for the cultists who follow the Black Sun or the Abyssal Lord, they often claim prophets appear among them. But as you know, the ‘prophets’ in their mouths are usually just madmen whose minds have been corrupted…”

“So that means that at least in the period from the Critt dynasty to the Dark Age, the gods could often contact the mortal world,” Duncan said thoughtfully. “They could even hold long conversations with certain mortals who met the conditions. But starting from the Age of City-States, their contact with the mortal world has sunk down to nothing more than vague hints?”

Hearing the captain’s words, which sounded full of hidden meaning, Vanna’s expression grew a bit strange. She could not help asking: “I… have never thought about it from that angle. Why are you suddenly asking about this?”

[Why am I suddenly asking about this…]

Duncan stayed silent for a moment, and in that silence, what rose in his mind was the picture he had seen not long ago in Tyrian’s office—

The Moon.

In the world he knew that had a Moon, there were no Four Gods. There was no Boundless Sea under the protection of the storm Goddess. There was no World's Wound hanging high in the sky, and no Starry Sky and demons hidden in the Deep Sea beneath the Abyssal Deep.

Ever since he saw that picture of the Moon, his heart had not been at peace. Countless guesses about this world almost filled his entire mind.

"I just suddenly became interested in the oldest secrets of this world," he said slowly. Then he let out a soft breath and nodded to Vanna and Morris. "I have already seen the warning you prepared for the Deep Sea Church and the Truth Academy. There is no problem with it. Go and contact your Church headquarters at sea."

Although they still had doubts in their hearts, and still felt some worry over the captain's heavy mood during these past two days, Morris and Vanna did not ask more. They lowered their heads at the same time: "Yes, Captain."

…

Lucretia woke from a series of chaotic, strange, and terrifying nightmares.

She looked toward the window.

The thick curtains blocked the light from outside. Only a little golden glow slipped through the gaps in the fabric, falling into the room and making everything look shadowy. The familiar furniture took on a faintly eerie air in the dim corners, as if the remains of the nightmare had seeped into the Mortal Realm and now crouched and hid between the light and shadow.

A soft rustling sound came from beside her.

"Mistress?"

The oddly shaped and creepy stuffed rabbit sat up next to her. It tilted its head and looked at Lucretia with the button eyes sewn onto its face. A

young girl’s voice came from its cotton-filled body.

Lucretia reached out and grabbed the stuffed rabbit doll, pulled it into her arms, and rubbed it hard. Then she raised her head and looked toward the window: “What time is it now?”

“There is still an hour before your usual waking time,” the stuffed rabbit doll answered honestly, letting its Mistress knead and squeeze it while it seemed to study Lucretia’s face. “You do not look very well. You were sleeping very restlessly just now… Did you have a nightmare again?”

“I dreamed about some strange things…” Lucretia rubbed her forehead and let go of the stuffed rabbit doll. “Pour me a drink.”

“All right.” The doll answered obediently. It hopped off the bed, jumped down to the floor, and took a wineglass from the small cabinet nearby. It poured half a glass for its Mistress. At the same time, it asked curiously: “What did you dream about? Is it because… the Old Master is coming, so you feel uneasy?”

The young girl’s voice carried a hint of nervousness. It was clear that just saying the words “Old Master” put it under great pressure.

Lucretia took the glass from the doll and drained it in one go. Then she let out a long breath: “I dreamed of the time when the Radiant Star almost ‘fell’ because it sailed too close to the border fog. But it was different from my real memory. In the dream, our ship fell out of the fog and then kept flying upward, ‘falling’ straight toward the World’s Wound.

“And there were many, many other ships, twisted into all sorts of shapes, falling from the whole world up into the sky… It was absurd and strange.”

As she spoke, she tossed the glass back to the stuffed rabbit doll beside her: “He is about to arrive. Of course that makes me a little nervous. But I am

not so nervous that I will start having nightmares because of it—Rabby, he is still my Father."

"Yes, Mistress." The stuffed rabbit doll bowed its head at once, very obedient. Then it could not help but remind her: "But you still should be careful. Having nightmares on a ship is not a good sign. The Old Master… is linked to Subspace, after all. And right now, he is drawing closer to you."

"I understand." Lucretia spoke casually. Then she got out of bed, walked barefoot to the window, and yanked open the heavy curtains.

Warm and bright "sunlight" instantly flooded the room.

The Sun had not fully risen yet. However, over the nearby sea, that huge floating glowing geometric body had already kept the entire waters in "eternal day" for a long time.

Lucretia narrowed her eyes and bathed in that endless "sunlight".

The voice of the stuffed rabbit doll sounded from behind her: "Mistress, are you still going to the 'stone sphere' today?"

"No." Lucretia shook her head and turned to walk toward the dressing table. "Today I am going into the city to say hello to some old friends in the Explorer Association."

Chapter 505: Doomsday Echo

Lightwind Harbor was one of the city-states closest to the edge of civilization. From the day it was built, it had always been one of the most important bases of the Truth Academy and the Explorer Association.

A thousand years ago, an expedition fleet led by an elven scholar lost its way in a storm near the border. While searching for a route, they discovered this large island that did not appear in any record.

According to the accounts, the fleet had been chased by the storm for a full seven days. On the morning of the eighth day, when everyone was exhausted, land suddenly appeared in the sunlight shining through a gap in the storm. The explorers were overjoyed. They used the last of their strength to steer their ships toward the shore.

Just as they neared this unknown island, the storm’s power suddenly weakened. By the time the crew could clearly see the lush vegetation on the island, the storm had completely vanished. Only a light breeze remained over the nearby sea.

So the explorers named the island “Lightwind”. Later, they turned that into the name of their new colony.

Many city-states were discovered when explorers wandered the seas. Their discoveries always came with some amount of dangers or legends. The stories were full of truth and lies, hard to tell apart. But the discovery and building of Lightwind Harbor had always been seen as “detailed and reliable”.

The reason was simple: it was a city-state founded by elves.

The explorer captain who first found this island was still the governor of the city-state today. At the same time, he also served as the guildmaster of the Explorer Association.

Sara Mell stood on the balcony of the governor’s residence and looked at the streets below, which were bathed in “sunlight”. He looked at the city-state that he and his companions had built up bit by bit and watched it grow prosperous.

Patrolling Steam Walkers marched in neat lines down the streets. Bicycle bells rang with a clear sound. citizens were getting ready to start their workday.

On the “tower” not far away, the round dome in elven style slowly opened under the push of machinery. A heavy filter lens array rose from the top of the tower and slowly adjusted its angle as it tracked the Sun climbing into the sky.

The elven governor narrowed his eyes a little. Wrinkles gathered at the corners of his eyes.

Even for the long-lived elves, Sara Mell was no longer young. Wrinkles had started creeping across his forehead three hundred years ago. The golden hair that elves were known for was now frosted with white. He had gone from a lively, energetic captain to a calm but frail old man.

But one thing had never changed—he was still full of curiosity about the world.

“Your Father was already a respectable explorer back in his day. Even by the strict standards of the elves, he could be called ‘extraordinary’. A warning from such an explorer to the civilized world is worth taking seriously. But I hope you understand—our doubts are also quite normal.”

Sara Mell turned and spoke to the black-haired lady sitting properly at the tea table on the balcony.

“I do understand. But my job is only to pass on the message. What you do with it is your business,” Lucretia said calmly. “Father also expected your reaction. His stance is the same—issue the warning, and leave the rest alone.”

“As for the Explorer Association, I will handle it,” Governor Sara said after a short pause. “In any case, the news from Captain Duncan is information that must be taken seriously. We should have the captains on the route raise their guard.”

Then he frowned. “But I am truly curious… Can you really dive into the Deep Sea with a spherical submersible and see the ‘original blueprint’ of our world?”

“The risk is very high, but people in Frostholm did succeed,” Lucretia nodded. “Of course, the pioneers half a century ago paid a heavy price for it. Mortal minds are too fragile in the end. They cannot fully avoid the influence of those ‘truths’ in the Deep Sea.

“My Father is… more or less special. I do not suggest you try to copy him.”

“If I were seven or eight hundred years younger, I would probably be planning my own dive right now,” Sara said after a few seconds of silence, shaking his head with some regret. “If I could witness those sights with my own eyes, I would have much more confidence when I tried to convince others in the Association.”

Lucretia smiled: “It does not matter. Very soon, more people will receive the warning. Father has already arranged to send alerts to the Churches of the Four Gods and to the various city-states. That should be enough to show how serious this is.”

Sara Mell nodded. Then he hesitated for a moment but could not stop himself from asking: “I am still very curious… Lady Lucretia, has your Father really recovered his humanity completely? I have lived for more than two thousand years, and I have never heard of anyone returning from Subspace. I have never heard of anyone who could even restore their humanity after coming back. How did he do it?”

“Who knows?” Lucretia shook her head. “If you are truly that curious, you can ask him yourself when the time comes—he is coming in person very soon, after all.”

Sara Mell’s calm face twitched in a way that could be seen with the naked eye.

“Lady, there is no need to stress that point again…” The elven governor spoke in a strange tone. “It is not good for the heart. Please be kind to old people.”

Lucretia laughed, clearly quite amused. She felt she had tasted the same pleasure Tyrian often enjoyed, and she rose from her chair, satisfied, and waved to the governor.

In the next second, the “Sea Witch” turned into a flurry of colorful paper slips. They spun in the air, caught by a gust of wind, and were swept away into the sky, vanishing from the balcony.

“This ‘witch’ truly comes and goes as she pleases…” Sara Mell could not help grumbling under his breath. He turned to go back inside. Next, he had to think about how to contact the Explorer Associations of other city-states and how to pass on that dreadful “warning”.

But just as he turned around, the governor’s movements suddenly stopped.

It was as if a wind full of terror had swept across the edge of his mind. A feeling of indescribable horror and despair surged up in his heart. Sara Mell

felt that this “emotion” had been poured directly into his head. In an instant, it seized his thoughts, turned his blood to ice, and made every muscle tense.

He struggled to lift his head and looked in a direction that felt carved deep into his mind, a direction that pulled at him with a powerful force. He looked toward the center of the city-state, toward those tall buildings—

Yet he did not see the city he knew, nor any other familiar scene.

He saw only a blinding sea of fire, and a single giant tree.

The tree was so huge that words could not describe it. He could no longer see its borders. It stood like a mountain range made of wood, burning fiercely at the edge of his vision.

The giant tree looked like the World Tree “Atlantis” spoken of in ancient elven legends, yet it was far more grand and awe-inspiring than anything poets or scholars had ever imagined. It seemed to cover whole mountains and plains and to shelter an entire kingdom under its shade.

It was bigger than any city-state or island Sara Mell had ever seen. The land under the tree was wider than anything he could picture—

And all of it was wrapped in Doomsday-like flames.

Red fire devoured everything, burning the huge tree and the forests around it to ash. From the edges of the fire, immense flashes of light burst forth over and over, like the release of horrible energy. They lit the air and tore open the sky.

Following those strange, immense flashes, Sara Mell slowly raised his gaze.

He finally found the source of the flames that were consuming all things.

It was the sky. The whole sky glowed with a terrifying, blistering light, like the swollen core of a steam reactor boiler about to enter a runaway state and

melt through its shell. In the center of that swelling glow, a dark red, ominous color began to seep out bit by bit.

Then the dark red color spread quickly, swallowing the bright light of the sky until nothing was left. The entire world fell into a dreadful, dark red dusk. The heat in the sky faded away, but everything on the ground had already burned to nothing.

The forest had become charred earth. The miracle-like giant tree collapsed in the embers, crashing down with a roar like heaven and earth breaking apart.

The dark-red sky grew darker and began to fill, little by little, with black streaks. Time seemed to pass for a very long while, or maybe only for a moment. Sara Mell saw the veil of night descend.

The strange night sky, black mixed with dark red, covered the world that had become a burned wasteland. In that extremely short “calm”, he seemed to hear people speaking right by his ear.

They were several unfamiliar voices—

“…I still remember them, remember what they looked like…”

“Memory can still be useful… We have a plan…”

“A Sanctuary World, or a prison where life can only struggle on—there is little hope for the future.”

“But at least there is still a future…”

Sara Mell looked around in fright, trying to find the source of the voices, but he saw only a world burned away and all things destroyed. Then the dark red sky of ill omen began to crack apart.

Chaotic bands of light poured in through the rifts in the sky. The ashes and ruins on the ground were absorbed and broken down by those lights in an

instant. All things were disappearing at great speed.

A powerful thought with no clear source roared in his head, like the voices of tens of millions of minds speaking together in harmony:

A torn Doomsday.

Sara Mell's body swayed.

Something retreated like the tide. The fierce emotions and frightening images left in his mind melted away like snow under sunlight. One second ago, he had felt that he had seen something, and he had even remembered it strongly. The next second, he felt he had only been staring off into space for a moment.

Those things were gone, like dreams fading in the morning.

Sara Mell stood there and frowned without thinking. He glanced back in the direction where the "Sea Witch" had disappeared just now.

"This 'witch' truly comes and goes as she pleases…"

Sara Mell could not help grumbling once more, and then he turned and went back into the room.

Chapter 506: Morris’s Teacher

Vanna went down to the lower deck, to the Prayer Room deep in the crew area. After she closed the door, she quickly set up the ritual field needed for Psychic Communication.

On the Boundless Sea, where conditions were limited, the ritual still used materials she could find on the ship. She used a large candlestick instead of a brazier and her own prayer book instead of the required sacred relic. On the floor she spread a mixture of salt and grease to draw storm runes and build the sacred space. Since this was already her second time, she was not as clumsy as before.

The feeling of a gaze suddenly came from the side, making Vanna, the inquisitor who was busy arranging the ritual field, stop in place.

She turned her head toward the source of that gaze and saw a round mirror hanging on the wall in the corner. Light and shadow rippled in the glass. A black-haired lady with hair falling over her shoulders was looking this way with curiosity.

From the mirror came Agatha’s voice: “Sorry, I did not mean to spy on someone else’s ritual. I was just drawn here by the noise.”

“It is fine. This is not a secret ritual,” Vanna said with a generous smile as she greeted this very special new “crew member” who had recently joined the Vanished. “I am about to contact the Cathedral ark.”

“Mm, I know. The ritual process of the Church of Death is a bit different, but I can more or less tell what you are doing. However…”

As Agatha in the mirror spoke, she suddenly stopped, hesitating.

“However what?” Vanna asked in confusion.

“…Is it really okay to set up a ritual site like this?” Agatha stared curiously at the scene in the cabin. “Using a candlestick instead of a brazier is still acceptable. Using an ordinary prayer book instead of a sacred relic… that barely makes sense too. But using coarse salt from the kitchen instead of the ‘purified salt’ blessed by divine blessing, and cooking oil instead of holy oil… Are the rituals of the Deep Sea Church really this free?”

Vanna suddenly felt a bit embarrassed. She said: “This… is mainly because the supplies on the ship are limited. We used up the holy oil earlier, and I forgot to replenish it when we were in port. But in my experience, it works fine.”

“…Then it seems you truly are a Saint deeply favored by the Goddess,” Agatha could not help sighing. “Most priests would never dare to borrow a deity’s power in such a casual way.”

The muscles in Vanna’s face twitched twice. She could only keep a straight face and reply: “Uh, thank you…”

“I will not disturb you then.” Agatha in the mirror waved her hand, and her figure slowly faded. “I will go see what Shirley is doing. The captain asked me to watch her do her homework…”

The mirror turned into a patch of darkness, then slowly returned to its normal reflection.

Vanna watched the lady in the mirror leave and stared blankly for a moment. Then she turned to look at the ritual field she had just arranged so carefully and slowly frowned.

“Is it really that makeshift?”

She muttered to herself with some doubt, then curled her finger and flicked in the direction of the candlestick. An invisible force ignited the candles at once. In the next second, the flames swelled and leapt, far brighter than normal candlelight. The runes drawn around the ritual field began to crackle, and the sound slowly mixed with the rising roar of waves.

“It works pretty well…”

Vanna thought this to herself, and in the next moment she let her spirit sink. Her mind and senses slowly immersed themselves in the surging sound of the waves around her.

The ritual drew down a deity’s gaze. The runes borrowed that deity’s power. Vanna let this power pull on her spirit and used it as a medium to call the distant Cathedral ark, waiting for Pope Helena’s response.

Psychic Resonance used a ritual to borrow the power of the Four Gods. That power strengthened the weak mental abilities mortals were born with, so they could communicate with priests far away who shared the same faith. This ancient divine magic was a skill every ordained priest had to learn. Even in these days of constant technological progress, even now that humans had created modern tools like telegraphs and telephones, this long-distance link between priests was still an important way for distant city-states to share information.

Vanna felt as if she entered a long, dark tunnel. Her soul raced through it. The walls looked like layers of black rock, but as she sped past, faint ripples seemed to move over that “rock”. They looked… as if they were about to come alive.

She put away stray thoughts, focused her mind, and held back any needless curiosity or urge to reach out. Vanna silently recited the rules she had long since memorized and tried her best not to get close to any solid-looking edge of this “tunnel”. Then she “saw” a glow slowly appear ahead.

Unlike the time she went to the Nameless King's tomb to attend a "gathering", today's Psychic Communication only pointed toward the great Storm Cathedral on the Boundless Sea. At the end of the "dark tunnel", a hazy, unreal space quickly took shape, and an elegant, dignified figure appeared in her sight.

Vanna stopped in front of that figure. Her own shadowy form quickly steadied.

"I salute you, Your Eminence."

"No need to stand on ceremony, Vanna. This hardly counted as a public setting." Helena's phantom returned the salute, then asked curiously: "Why did you call me so suddenly? Did something happen on that ship?"

"Everything on the ship is normal—but something else has happened." Vanna took a light breath, steadied her feelings, and then spoke slowly: "I am here to deliver a warning from Captain Duncan. The Vanished is warning the entire civilized world…"

Warm yellow light lit up the old shelves and ancient scrolls. On the wide walnut desk, delicate alchemy tools kept a complex chemical reaction going. In the large, old-fashioned study, an elderly elf with a plump figure and kindly face sat calmly by the desk. He was the leader of the Truth Academy and the Pope of Rahm, the God of Wisdom: Rune.

The old elf was gazing at the alchemy apparatus on the desk, but in his eyes the scene reflected there came from far away—

"The Vanished is warning the entire civilized world. We have confirmed a sign of awakening from the Elder God 'Abyssal Lord' in the Deep Sea beneath Frostholm. This process of awakening may appear again under any city-state. There is evidence that the Abyssal Lord's flesh exists in all things…"

The short, plump, kindly elf silently listened to the voice from far away. His expression slowly grew serious. When the other side finally finished speaking, he rose from the desk and walked toward a bookshelf at the far end of the room. “Morris, if we made the most extreme parts of this message public, the whole world would see them as the most horrifying heresy in history. Even the Annihilators would think it was a bit too extreme.”

“There is no such thing as heresy on the road to Truth, teacher. In the ‘classics’ created by mortals, there are only two kinds: those that have already been overturned and those waiting to be overturned. You are the one who told me that.”

Morris’s voice sounded calm and powerful, with a hidden edge of stubbornness and courage. It made the elf elder think back to many years ago, when this gifted young human was still studying at the Truth Academy. Back then, he carried the same drive, digging for every answer and boldly questioning every problem.

Such curiosity and drive were blazing and dangerous in a scholar. Countless gifted youths used that force to climb the peaks of Truth at great speed. Many of them were struck down by the dangers of knowledge itself during the climb. Others managed to calm down and, under a mentor’s protection and mental guidance, learned to rein in their talent and sip the trickling stream of Truth with care.

A much smaller group, outstanding students like Morris, chose a third path —

In two years they mastered shooting with all kinds of light and heavy weapons, the use of blades and other cold weapons, demolitions, occult studies, self-defense arts, and mixed fighting techniques.

They were the pride of the Truth Academy and its affiliated combat school.

Rune stopped in front of the tall bookshelf and reached out to pull out a record book.

He opened it and slowly flipped through. On each page, the faces and figures of past students looked back at him. Their youngest days were preserved in the magic-filled pages. Some stood shyly. Some waved at the viewer. Some made funny faces. Some laughed out loud.

A young human stood in a classroom doorway with his arms crossed, looking this way with full confidence. Under the black-and-white image were the words “Morris Underwood” and his student record.

“Yes, I did teach you that. Mortals’ classics come in only two kinds: those that have been overturned and those still waiting to be overturned… There is no heresy on the road to Truth, because real Truth does not need anyone’s approval. It simply exists, forever…”

Rune murmured to himself. One of his eyes looked at the student on the page, while in the other eye the same student’s present face was still reflected—white hair already touched his temples, completely unlike the energetic youth in the record.

The lives of humans were very short. For elves, forming deep bonds with humans was actually hard and painful. These friends and students always grew old quickly, and before the elves could react, they turned into a handful of dust. Memories and partings came very suddenly. Every bit of sorrow arrived late, and always with regret that could not be undone.

Yet Rune still gladly accepted and taught apprentices from human society.

Because even in their short lives, these apprentices could show learning abilities that amazed the elves. The desire to explore and the many possibilities born from that short span of life were, in Rune’s eyes, precious traits in the pursuit of Truth.

Morris’s voice sounded in his mind again: “Captain Duncan thinks we must share every piece of information we have with the Four Gods Church and only keep some things back when we talk with the city-states and the Explorer Association. The Four Gods Church has both the power and the understanding to know how to handle this warning.”

“…That sounds quite reasonable, but has he considered another possibility?” Rune said slowly. “The contents of this warning are too shocking. They sound even more extreme than the heresies preached by the Annihilators. The Church might see it as a kind of… hostility, even as a new heretical doctrine. For some more conservative priests, their first reaction will not be to accept it as a ‘warning’. They will be more likely to treat it as an attack on their faith.”

“He does not care.”

“Oh?”

“The storm is coming, and thunder sounds first as a warning—but the thunder itself does not care whether mortals hide or not. That is the captain’s attitude.”

“…Reasonable.”

Chapter 507: The Popes of the Four Gods

When a storm came, mortals scattered in all directions at the roar of thunder. Yet the thunder itself did not care how mortals reacted. Its roar came only from its own existence. In the same way, the very existence of the Vanished was enough to interfere with the order of the entire Boundless Sea.

Under this premise, wondering whether “Captain Duncan” would care about being treated as a heretic by mortal churches became meaningless. That would be overestimating how much the people of this world could affect that being from the Subspace Shadows. And if one thought about it from another angle, the image of the Vanished in the eyes of the civilized world was never much better than that of a “heretic” anyway…

“I will discuss this with Popes Helena, Banster, and Frem,” Rune said to Morris. “There will certainly be voices of doubt and fear among the bishops, but the four of us should be able to reach a common stance quickly. Whatever the source of the news, the warning itself must be taken seriously.”

“I knew you would look at this calmly,” Morris’s voice carried a hint of relief. “You are still the same as back then.”

“You, however, are very different from back then, Morris,” Rune said with a sigh. “When I first heard you had fallen into a deep slump, many people were sorry about it. I did not expect you to pull yourself together again so

quickly. I even less expected that your ‘recovery’… would come in the form of joining the Vanished. To be honest, after these long centuries, very few things can still shock me. This is one of the most shocking.”

“Life on the ship is actually not bad—one could even say it is better than living in a city-state. Life at sea brings some trouble, but here I see new things almost every day and deal with all kinds of things I had never even heard of before…”

“You already sound exactly like a crew member who is proud of his own ship,” Rune could not help saying. “I really am a bit curious. What exactly are you doing on that ship?”

Morris was silent for half a minute.

Many scenes flashed through his mind—giving lessons to Abyssal demons, to a cursed doll, and to demon contractors; racing in the Spirit Realm; eating Deep Sea spawn; keeping a fragment of the Sun company while it read; then watching as that fragment braised various heretic abominations that crawled out of books every day…

“…Active and wholesome academic research,” Morris said seriously.

“Oh, that does sound quite good.” Rune nodded, but could not help adding a warning. “Still, I must say that you should stay alert. Maybe, as you said, ‘Captain Duncan’ really has regained his humanity. But as a mortal, living on the Vanished and chatting easily with a Subspace Eldritch God is dangerous in itself. You must deal carefully with all unknown things and avoid letting your mind and understanding be affected…”

“Thank you for the warning, teacher, but please do not worry. You know I have always been a cautious student. Even back in the Academy, when I carried out the most dangerous research, I always made full preparations and never had an accident.”

Rune, who had returned to his seat behind the desk, fell silent at those words.

In his mind, the old elf could not help remembering the days many years ago when Morris studied at the Truth Academy.

Cautious… There were indeed many cautious students in the Academy, but not everyone understood that word the same way.

Some students, when they saw a dangerous tome, first tried to seal it away and stay as far from it as possible. That was called being cautious.

There was another kind of student. When they came into contact with forbidden knowledge, the first thing they did was gulp down half a bottle of mixed magic potions, hang themselves all over with charm amulets, and then prepare three largest-caliber pistols. They also called that being cautious.

The second kind of student had a high chance of dying suddenly. But the ones who survived often achieved great things. The most legendary scholars of the Truth Academy were often like that.

Yet even among the most legendary of them, none had ever reached the point of running off to the Vanished to chat and laugh with a Subspace Eldritch God.

After a long quiet, the elf behind the desk finally broke the silence in a low voice: “Morris…”

“Yes, teacher?”

“…You are someone who is meant to do big things.”

“Thank you for your expectations.”

“No, what I mean is, if one day the trouble you cause is really too big, you must tell me in advance. If I can help, I will help. If I cannot, at least I can

run away early.”

“…”

The link created by the Psychic Communication broke. The resonance of thought and perception ebbed away like the tide. Rune narrowed his eyes slightly, feeling his former apprentice’s presence leave. Only after he confirmed that Morris’s mind had safely withdrawn from the psychic channel did he fully relax.

Yet a faint, strange noise, like countless people whispering under their breath, still lingered in his mind. It took a long time to fade.

Feeling how that noise affected his own mind, Rune could not help letting out a quiet sigh.

“…A permanent madness threshold, yet he can still stay clear and rational… This really is unbelievable. Is this also an effect from that ‘captain’?”

Muttering softly to himself, this elf—perhaps the most learned among all mortals—shook his head. Then he sat quietly by the desk, as if waiting for someone to come calling.

He did not wait long.

A hazy sound of waves suddenly rose in his mind and slowly grew into clear, rolling surf. Right after came calls of flame and death. Rune sighed at these calls, glanced at the alchemical vessel still reacting on the side table, and, after making sure there was enough material left inside, let his mind sink once more.

This study was his ritual ground for holding Psychic Communication. Every old shelf and solemn book here, along with the alchemy apparatus on the desk, served as part of the ritual.

Darkness surged up and then scattered like mist. At the end of a deep, dim passage, the figures of three Popes appeared: the Popes of the Deep Sea, of Death, and of Flamebearer.

Rune passed through the passage and came before his three old friends. He nodded slightly in greeting, and before they could speak, he said on his own: “It seems you have also received the news.”

“Banster and I each received messages from our own Saints,” said Helena, Pope of the Deep Sea. At the same time she pointed at the tall, silent figure across from her. “Frem just arrived. We only had time to tell him the general situation.”

The tall figure called Frem gave a small nod.

He was the leader of Flamebearer, the representative in the mortal world of Everburning Ember Tarrigan. In appearance, he was perhaps the most striking of the four Popes. His unusually tall body, rock-like gray, tough skin, and the metallic lines on that skin all showed his race.

He was a strong Senkin, dressed in a dark-gold robe that marked his role as Pope of Flamebearer. His short hair was gray-white, his features sharp, and he looked silent and extremely serious.

In recent times, this Pope of Flamebearer had been leading his patrol fleet along the borders of the civilized world and rarely took part in gatherings of the four Mortal Realms. This was his first appearance in some time.

“I still have not fully understood the situation,” Frem said. His voice was so deep it sounded like it came out of stone. “None of my Saints have been lured onto that ship yet.”

At his words, Helena’s expression turned strange. She frowned and said in a low voice: “Our Saints were not lured onto it either…”

“They met Captain Duncan. They were wary of Captain Duncan. They agreed with Captain Duncan. They joined Captain Duncan.” Frem glanced at Helena. His expression still looked like a stone. “I think that counts as being lured.”

Helena could only say: “…”

The tall, thin, and aged Pope of Death, Banster, coughed lightly when he saw this. “It is not your first day knowing Frem. He has always been like this.”

“…All right.” Helena was speechless for a moment, then nodded slowly. “We are not here today to talk about ‘Saints being lured onto the ship’. We are here to talk about the warning from the Vanished.”

Rune raised his head. “Do you have anything you want to ask?”

“Yes.” Helena spoke at once. Her eyes fell on Rune. “I want to know what those huge biological masses under the city-states really are. From the description, they sound very much like the Leviathan beasts that carry the Cathedral arks. Are they the same thing or not?”

“All four Cathedral arks were built by the Truth Academy. The technology to ‘revive’ and control Leviathans also came from you,” Banster added, turning to look at Rune as well. “But you have never told us where you found those ‘corpses’ of Leviathans, nor have you said anything about the link between those Leviathan beasts and the structures at the bottom of the city-states. We have reason to think the Truth Academy holds some special ‘truth’.”

Frem did not speak. He only kept his statue-like expression and calmly gazed into Rune’s eyes.

Faced with these three pressing gazes, Rune only spread his hands calmly.

“I also do not know what is under the city-states.”

“You do not know?” Helena’s eyes widened a little. “The Truth Academy ‘revived’ four Leviathans, and you say you do not know what the ‘Leviathan’ under the city-states is about?”

Rune only answered with a calm question of his own: “The storm Goddess Gamona is the Queen of the Leviathans. As her chosen, do you know more than I do?”

Helena frowned and did not speak.

“I believe you must have already tried asking the Leviathan that carries the great Storm Cathedral. I am sure it could not give you any answers—because even they themselves do not understand their own kind.”

Rune sighed and shook his head gently.

“The history of our world has been shattered. Even ancient giant beasts cannot clearly remember what happened before the Great Annihilation. Do you know, that ‘Captain Duncan’ even gave this phenomenon a name…”

“He calls it the ‘Horizon Limit’ on the time dimension.”

Chapter 508: The Cathedral Ark’s Secret

All known history of this world started with the Great Annihilation of the Age of Antiquity.

If one treated the Great Annihilation as a wall, then that invisible wall was clearly not a simple event node. In truth, it cut the entire historical Time-Stream.

Everything before the Great Annihilation was unknown. Archaeological scholars exhausted all their wisdom and effort, yet could not restore even a shred of information from the node of time before that moment. In the whole world, people could not find a single relic that pointed to the era before the Great Annihilation—not even a stone carved with words.

In the eyes of scholars, this hopeless black wall had already stood for ten thousand years. Now, Captain Duncan, who had returned from Subspace, had given this barrier a fitting name.

As leader of the Truth Institute and Pope of the God of Wisdom, Rune felt the presence of that black wall more deeply than anyone, and he understood how precise the term “Horizon Limit” was.

“Our world feels as if it was ‘created out of thin air’ at some moment after the Great Annihilation. Our broken and self?contradictory history is ironclad proof that this Horizon Limit exists,” Rune said, his tone full of emotion as he faced his three old friends. “Since the rise of the city?states, even since the Dark Age, countless scholars have tried to trace the past and

search for the ‘source’ before the Great Annihilation. They dug ever deeper into the dark earth, but in the end they were all blocked by that invisible barrier.”

“Not even a single second— not even the one second before the Great Annihilation began—can be confirmed. It is blank. Even the ‘Three Long Nights’ mentioned in the Blasphemous Tome that Captain Duncan took from the Annihilators only describes the span of history between the Great Annihilation and the founding of the ancient kingdom of Critt. As for any information from before the Horizon Limit, it is still a complete blank.”

“It is very dangerous to treat a cultist’s heretical ravings as reference material,” Banster, Pope of Death, could not help but remind him from the side.

Rune lightly shook his head. “The danger of heretical doctrines lies in their power to tempt and to incite evil. If we strip away those influences, the ‘Three Long Nights’ themselves are still a topic worth studying. Many of our results on the Dark Age after the collapse of the ancient kingdom of Critt are built on research into the Church of the Sun and the Cult of Annihilation.”

“…So in the end, what you are saying is that you cannot explain the ‘Leviathan’ beneath the city?states, and those Leviathan beasts that carry the Cathedral arks cannot give us an answer either,” Frem broke the silence. “Because this was something that happened before the Great Annihilation, all information that points to it is unknowable, unmeasurable, and unprovable.”

Rune did not speak, which was as good as agreeing with Frem.

Helena thought for a moment, then suddenly spoke. “But you can at least tell us where the Truth Institute found those four Leviathans. At the very

least, the beasts that carry the four Cathedral arks really were discovered and ‘revived’ by your people, weren’t they?”

“…They came from the frontier, after a large?scale ‘Border Collapse,’” Rune finally gave a clear answer this time. “The exact location… was near the Eternal Veil in the eastern sea.”

“The eastern sea?” Banster frowned without thinking.

“Yes, right by the former site of the Viseran Thirteen Isles,” Rune nodded. “Ever since that terrible Subspace disaster a century ago, the eastern stretch of the Eternal Veil has always been a fragile node. The dense fog there often collapses inward, or temporary Vision zones appear over the sea. You should know this as well.”

Helena and Frem nodded in silence, while a thoughtful look appeared on Banster’s face. None of them interrupted Rune; they signaled for him to go on.

“When the Truth Institute was in charge of patrolling the frontier, one of our ships encountered an anomaly there,” Rune went on, sorting through his memories as he spoke. “The exact situation can no longer be verified, because during the event the crew suffered severe cognitive confusion and memory gaps. Afterwards, they could not accurately describe what they had experienced. But there was a hastily written log on the ship that recorded part of what happened—

“‘The sea suddenly sank inward, like a strange bowl. The edge of the “bowl” was smooth and calm, and the water seemed to have frozen in place. But the ship did not fall down with the sunken sea. Instead, it floated above that sunken region… The ship lost all power. It could not move forward or back, and hung in the air hundreds of meters above the water in a terrifying way… Colossal shapes surfaced from that sunken sea, as if some kind of living creatures…’

“That was what one crew member managed to write down in a hurry before his cognition broke down and his memories were damaged.

“Later, another of our fleets found that missing patrol ship. It was slowly drifting out of a patch of thin fog, completely without power, its steam core cold. Everyone aboard was asleep. And behind that ship, deep in the slowly thinning fog, four massive shapes appeared in the rescuers’ field of view.

“Those were the Leviathans we discovered at sea—the colossal beasts recorded in the Storm Canon, long vanished from the river of history, apostles of the Storm Goddess.

“What happened after that, you already know. The Truth Institute found a way to ‘revive’ those legendary beasts and built vast Cathedral arks upon their backs, then handed them over for the Church of the Four Gods to use.”

Rune finished his account. Frem and Banster were still lost in thought, while Helena slowly furrowed her brow. “So those Leviathans were actually one of the Frontier Relics… No wonder you always avoided talking about these details before. So it was related to a Border Collapse.”

“Awareness of Border Collapse increases the chance of a Border Collapse occurring inside the civilized world. The closer in time, the higher the probability. This was a rule that Captain Duncan Abnomar summarized a century ago, back when he was still a great explorer,” Rune nodded. “But now, decades have passed since the Border Collapse in which the Truth Institute discovered the Leviathans. Bringing it up again is not quite so dangerous.”

“…I have a question,” Frem suddenly said. “The Cathedral arks may be large, but compared to the city?states they clearly are not on the same scale. If the biological structure under the cities really is also a Leviathan, then its size is several times that of the Leviathans under the Cathedral arks… Are they really from the same species?”

“Who knows?” Rune spread his hands. “Perhaps the four Leviathans we found on the frontier were just some kind of ‘small individuals.’ Or ‘juveniles.’”

“…In theory it should not be like that,” Helena shook her head. “I often communicate with the Leviathan of the Cathedral ark. It does not know what happened before the Great Annihilation or the truth beneath the city? states, but it has clearly said that it is an adult Leviathan.”

“Then the problem lies in the biological structures beneath the cities. Perhaps they are unusually huge ‘mutant individuals,’ or perhaps… they are connected to the influence of those ‘Blueprints’ in the Deep Sea,” Rune said, guessing as he went. “After all, if the information sent by the Vanished is true, then all the city?states now on the Boundless Sea can actually be counted as the ‘creations’ of the Elder Gods. Even the biological structures beneath the cities are likely the result of a ‘second round of processing’ by the Abyssal Lord…”

At this point Rune suddenly stopped. He shook his head with a touch of self?mockery, then passed his hand over his eyes and made a gesture of prayer to God of Wisdom Rahm. “May the Lord forgive me. It feels truly strange to be talking about such heretical claims.”

“May the Lord forgive us.”

Helena and Frem also made gestures of benediction, confessing to the Storm Goddess and the Everburning Ember behind them.

As leaders of the Church, they could look at these borderline?taboo, even outright heretical topics from a higher vantage. They could analyze information from heretic fanatics with cooler heads and a more practical attitude. But as Heralds of the Four Gods, they also held to their sects’ teachings and were bound by their faith. When they spoke of certain

dangerous subjects, that inner sense of unease and resistance was hard to avoid.

Only Banster, the Herald of the God of Death, tall, gaunt, and aged in appearance, had kept silent, as if he had been lost in thought from the very beginning.

“Banster,” Rune finally turned his attention to this silent spokesman of the Death God. “You have seemed distracted from the start.”

“I am thinking about a question, Rune,” Banster finally lifted his head. His sunken eye sockets were deep as night. “The Viseran Thirteen Isles—the place where the Leviathans were found was near the sea where the Viseran Thirteen Isles incident happened. Do you not find that worth paying attention to?”

Rune nodded calmly. Clearly, he had already expected Banster to focus on this detail.

“I know what you want to say—the Vanished,” the elven elder said slowly. “A hundred years ago, the Vanished opened a gate to Subspace at the Viseran Thirteen Isles and dragged all those islands and their residents into the terrifying depths of that world. That event also left the entire sea region with a fragile space?time Anomaly, with Visions occurring again and again… In that sense, the incident that patrol ship from the Truth Institute encountered decades ago is causally linked to the Viseran Thirteen Isles incident.”

At this point he paused, then looked up and gazed seriously at Banster. “But we cannot simply conclude that ‘it was the Vanished that sent the Leviathan beasts into the Mortal Realm.’ We lack evidence, and there is not enough theoretical support.”

“But those four Leviathans could indeed have entered our Mortal Realm because of some later effect of the Viseran Thirteen Isles incident, Rune. This matter was risky from the very beginning.”

“…So you don’t want your Cathedral ark anymore?”

“I want it.”

Chapter 509: Banster’s Thoughts

Banster’s reply was simple, direct, and honest.

For a moment, Rune did not even react.

“Then why say so much?” the short, plump Rune could not help but mutter. “With all that doubt, I almost thought you were going to go back today and seal up your Cathedral ark…”

“I am only stressing the risks behind this matter.” Banster’s expression did not change at all. His thin, bloodless face looked extremely solemn. “We all know what happened back then at the Viseran Thirteen Isles. ‘The Sinking of the Isles’ is only a mild, compromise term. In essence, the whole thing was a large?scale connection between our Mortal Realm and Subspace. That sea region is still not stable even now, and those Leviathans…”

“They are safe, Banster,” Rune calmly cut in. His blue eyes seemed soaked with a cool, wise light. “I am not some mad scholar who would, on a whim, drag a Frontier Relic into the civilized world. The ‘corpses’ of those Leviathans first went through ten full years of study and testing in the test waters of the Truth Institute. Only after we ruled out all unstable factors did I decide to turn them into Cathedral arks.”

Banster fell silent for a moment. After more than ten seconds, Frem finally broke the quiet in a deep voice: “No matter what, under the conditions at the time we had to build the Pilgrimage arks. Rune did take some risks, but without those arks, we would probably have already lost contact with the Four Gods.”

In the chaotic darkness, the four figures fell silent together.

“…Sometimes I really cannot help but think that the four ‘Leviathans’ that appeared at the eastern frontier were some kind of gift from fate,” Rune shook his head and muttered softly. “Without them, the Truth Institute would never have been able to build Pilgrimage arks large enough to serve as a ‘worldly Divine Realm,’ and the other plans we had at the time all had a slim chance of success. My friends, I admit I did hide many details about those Leviathans, but I hope you understand. It was a Border Collapse, after all. When I delivered the arks back then, I told you not to be curious about their origin. Just treat them as sacred miracles.”

“A gift from fate…” Banster spoke slowly. “If I had a choice, I would rather not hear that phrase. To me, it feels like a bloody sacrificial rite, offering the countless living beings of the Viseran Thirteen Isles to that ship in exchange for the four Pilgrimage arks we have today.”

“You cannot put it like that. There is no evidence that the appearance of the Leviathans was the work of the Vanished. It is just that all things in the world are connected, and some events happen to become linked with others,” Rune said, trying to soothe him. “Besides, that ship now sails on the Boundless Sea. Whether you want to admit it or not, its master has already regained his humanity. The warnings from the Vanished are like the warnings Captain Duncan gave a century ago, when he first discovered the phenomenon of Border Collapse. They are something we must face and take seriously. As I always say…”

“Truth does not change with people’s attitudes, for it exists on its own forever.” Banster waved a hand. “I know. I have heard you repeat that so often that my ears have grown calluses.”

Helena looked up at Rune, then at Banster, and spoke after a moment’s hesitation: “Banster, if you still feel uneasy, why not try speaking directly

with this ‘Captain Duncan’? See what his attitude is now, and maybe… confirm the truth of what happened at the Viseran Thirteen Isles back then. Even though he has publicly said that his memories are damaged, if you meet him in person…”

Before she could finish, Banster had already waved his hand sharply.

“Helena, among all your outrageous ideas, this one is especially over the top.”

“All right, I was only making a suggestion.”

“At this stage, we really must still be cautious in how we communicate with the Vanished,” Rune added at the right moment. “Our current level of contact is already quite bold. Any further… and we must consider the influence of Subspace. We cannot allow even the slightest chance of the Pilgrimage arks being corrupted.”

Frem, as steady as a stone giant, slowly shifted his gaze at those words, letting his eyes pass over the three Popes who were talking.

“Yet the three of you still let your Saints get lured onto that ship…”

Helena and Rune spoke at the same time: “They were not lured onto the ship!”

After the other two finished, Banster added unhurriedly, “My Saint is still in the Cathedral. It is only a shadow that boarded the ship.”

In the next second, the chaotic darkness fell silent once more, as if an awkward, subtle mood was now hanging between the four.

In the end, Rune was the first to break the silence. “In any case, none of you have told your Saints the truth about the ‘Leviathans’ under the Cathedral arks, have you?”

“No,” Helena was the first to shake her head. “When I heard Vanna mention the shocking structure beneath the city, I did immediately think of the Leviathans, but I did not reveal anything to her.”

Banster also shook his head. “Rather than adding to the confusion of the priests under me, I prefer to first come to you, old man, and figure out what is really going on—though it seems now that you only know so much yourself.”

Frem was the third to shake his head. “My Saint was not lured onto the ship…”

The other three finally shouted in unison: “Will you ever let that go?!”

“…I will keep quiet now.”

“Keeping it from them for now is the right choice,” Rune said, giving Frem, solid as a stone giant, a rather helpless look before turning back to nod at Helena and Banster. “We have too little information right now. First we need to find a way to confirm what is actually beneath the cities and whether the intelligence from the Vanished is accurate before we decide on the next steps.”

He paused, then added, “When conditions are right, we can contact ‘that ship’ again through our Saints. For now… let us first discuss the rest of the warning from the Vanished.”

All their expressions grew grave at his words.

“I will share my view first,” Banster spoke up. “I think we need to build a ‘monitoring’ system in response to the warning from the Vanished, one that stretches across the Church, the city?states, and the ocean?going fleets. Its coverage must be wide and its reach complete, because if the warning is true and the Elder Gods really dwell in all things, then any blind spot left

outside this net could become the Primordial Blast Point that leads to the next ‘Frostholm Crisis.’

“On top of that, the patrol fleets of the major Churches must also make matching changes, just as… we once did when we kept watch for ‘Border Collapse.’”

Helena gave Banster a slightly surprised look.

“It seems Rune’s worries just now were unnecessary. You are taking the warning from the Vanished seriously enough. I thought you would question every piece of intelligence from that ship because of the Viseran Thirteen Isles incident.”

“It is precisely because of the Viseran Thirteen Isles and the recent ‘Frostholm Crisis,’” Banster said with special gravity, his tone low and serious, “that I am sure of one thing: anything related to that ship cannot be a small matter. So I will keep a close watch on everything connected to that ship—closer than anyone else.”

…

The pitch?black sea surface quickly returned to normal. The chaotic shadows that had filled the sky were slowly replaced by sunlight. The sky and the sea once more showed bright colors, warm and calm. The pale green flames that had spread over the whole ship also died down and drew back as the vessel left the Spirit Realm.

The spirit form flames on Duncan’s body gradually faded as well. He let go of the wheel and felt the surging power slowly calm.

The wheel began to adjust itself, and creaks came from deep within the hull—Goathead had taken over the control of the ship. The Vanished’s speed dropped again and slowly returned to its usual cruising pace.

Just as Duncan left the helm, Alice ran over in high spirits: “Captain! Captain! Have we reached the south?”

“How could we?” Duncan gave the Doll a helpless look. “Do you know how far it is from Frostholm to Lightwind Harbor?”

Alice scratched her hair. “Oh. I saw you slow down, and the Vanished left its Spirit Realm state, so I thought we had arrived…”

“We only surfaced into the Mortal Realm to ‘get some fresh air,’” Duncan said casually. “Staying in deep Spirit Realm cruise for too long is bad for body and mind, and there are quite a few normal humans on this ship…”

He suddenly stopped halfway through his words, then shook his head.

“Coming back to the Mortal Realm, feeling the sea breeze and basking in the Sun eases the pressure of long voyages. And the Vanished itself needs a rest as well.”

“That makes sense,” Alice nodded slightly, a happy smile on her face. “They really were all tense. Once we came back under the sunlight, they relaxed a lot.”

Duncan knew that the “they” in this Doll’s mouth actually referred to the buckets, ropes, and pots and pans on the ship. He had no idea when she had grown so close with the living things aboard this vessel that she could even see the “moods” of those noisy little objects…

But all of this was a good thing.

“Goathead will handle the helm for a while. I will go rest,” Duncan said to Alice. “For dinner today, we’ll have baked flatbread, fish fillets, and vegetable soup.”

“Aye!” Alice answered at once, delighted.

Then the Doll girl lifted her head and glanced at the sky.

The Sun was already sinking toward the horizon. The outer ring of the double rune rings had begun to slip below the sea’s surface.

“Then I’ll go cook!”

With a shout, Alice turned and ran toward the galley.

Duncan watched her with a smile until her figure vanished through the cabin door at the end of the deck.

Then he let out a soft breath and turned toward the door of the captain’s cabin at the stern.

The Door of the Lost Ones.

Duncan’s gaze swept over the line of letters on the door. He placed his hand on the handle and pushed the door open.

Chapter 510: Answer

Zhou Ming returned to his studio apartment. Everything was still exactly the same as when he had left.

As he stepped onto the familiar, slightly worn floor and looked at the things in the room that had never changed, he listened to the steady hum of the computer tower that was always on. His thoughts finally began to settle.

A subtle, hard-to-describe feeling rose in his chest. Zhou Ming stepped over the bits of clutter on the floor, walked to the tightly closed window, and looked at the rolling white fog outside.

He stared at the fog for a long time, then reached out and pushed the window. As expected, it did not move at all.

The flour scattered on the windowsill and the stack of empty cans he had arranged on purpose were still exactly as before. They seemed to wordlessly send him a lonely, silent message.

For a long time, he just stood quietly at the window, as if he were looking into the thick fog, though his mind was completely blank. He did not know how much time passed before he suddenly blinked and turned his head to the side, like a stone statue that had just awakened.

Beside the unmade bed, the computer monitor on the desk glowed faintly. The “Network not connected” message still popped up from time to time in the lower right corner. The notebook he had used for notes before leaving was still tossed in a corner of the desk. He had not opened it for a long time.

Zhou Ming walked over and sat down at the desk. He stared blankly at the empty screen for a while, then pulled the keyboard and mouse out from the corner where he had shoved them. He opened the browser and casually typed a line of text into the search box:

“Does the world beyond the fog still exist?”

Of course, the browser did not show any useful search results. After he hit Enter, the cursor blinked a few times. Then an error page popped up. The network connection was interrupted, and the remote server did not respond.

The result was within his expectations. Zhou Ming already knew this would happen. Long ago, when the fog had first sealed off the room, he had used this computer in its strange state to try every way he could think of to contact the outside world.

He did not expect anything different to appear on the screen this time.

He had only wanted to type that sentence out, not to ask anyone, and not expecting any answer.

Listening to the monotonous hum of the fan, Zhou Ming let out a breath, tossed the keyboard and mouse back into the corner, then picked up the notebook. He flipped to a blank page and bent over it to write carefully:

“To the world beyond the thick fog, greetings from the man in the room.

“Soon, I will arrive at a place on the ‘other side’ of the door. It is a city-state on the frontier, and I am going there to confirm a few things.

“But even if I do not confirm them, I think I already know the answer. On the strange world beyond the door, countless unimaginable things are really happening, and my ‘intuition’ over there has always been very accurate.

“Because of this, I no longer expect any reply from beyond the fog. I no longer expect anyone to pass through the fog and knock on my door or my

window. I still cannot be sure what has happened to this world, but perhaps… it is not I who changed, but you.

“In my quiet, narrow little room, everything is still the way it used to be. Here I have a bed, a sofa, a coffee table, a desk, and a chair. My wardrobe stands beside the bed, and there is a large shelf as well. Most of the space on that shelf is still empty now…

“I have not cleaned this room for a long time.

“There is almost no dust here. I know that in human homes, more than half of the dust comes from flakes of skin that humans shed and from the wear and tear of daily life. Since I spend most of my time away from here, most parts of this room are still quite clean.

“But even without much dust, the room still looked a bit messy. The last few times I came back, I was always in a hurry, and I never tidied things up before I left.

“Leaving it messy all the time is not good. If everything really is as I think, then I feel… I should make this room completely clean and neat.

“Also, perhaps I should not say this. Perhaps these words are already meaningless, but… I hope all of you beyond the fog are safe and well.

“Goodbye. I am going to clean this room now.”

Zhou Ming let out a soft breath, tossed the pen back into the pen holder, carefully read over what he had just written, then closed the notebook and set it in the corner of the desk.

Then he stood up in silence and began to carry out what he had planned in the notebook, to clean and tidy the room.

He started with the slightly messy bed, folding the blanket and straightening the pillows and sheets. Then he moved on to the things on the desk, the

things on the coffee table, then the wardrobe, the bookshelf, and the clutter on the sofa and floor.

There was not much dust, and he did not need to mop the floor. With a single sheet of paper, he wiped away the thin layer of dust on the surfaces of the furniture, then tossed it into the wastebasket.

At the very end, Zhou Ming stood in front of the window.

He silently looked at the things on the windowsill. After standing there for a long time, he reached out and put away the tools he had used in the past to try to force the window open, including a hammer and a wrench, back into the toolbox nearby. Then he put the stacked cans and other odds and ends back where they belonged.

Then he wet a tissue, held it in his left hand, and pressed it against the windowsill. He held that pose for a full ten seconds, finally took a deep breath, and slowly wiped across the sill.

The flour he had used to check whether anyone had opened the window and entered the room was wiped away completely by the damp tissue.

Now the room was completely clean and tidy.

Zhou Ming let out a breath and calmly looked around the room, checking the results of his work. Then he picked up the bag of trash he had just gathered. The black plastic bag was not very heavy, since it mostly held wastepaper and empty cans, but when he lifted it, he still felt that it had some weight to it.

Carrying the bag of things he needed to throw away, he walked to the door of the studio apartment and opened it.

As always, pitch black, churning fog surged at the doorway. It seemed to hide all the secrets of this world, yet it was so chaotic that reason could not see through it.

Standing before the rolling black fog, Zhou Ming hesitated for a moment. Then he lifted his hand and threw the bag of trash into the mist.

The moment the plastic bag left his hand, a strong urge rose in him to grab it back. It was as if those scraps of paper and empty cans were the last treasures in this world, and he was the last gambler, forced to guard every gram of matter in the room. But he forced that urge down. He opened his hand and calmly watched the plastic bag fall to the other side of the door and vanish at once into the seething fog.

He knew that those things would not really reach the other side of the door. Only he himself could arrive in that world as “Duncan”. All other matter would disappear into the surging fog as it passed through the doorway.

Now those things that should be thrown away had completely vanished into the “world outside the room”.

Zhou Ming wiped his hands, stepped forward, and got ready to leave this place. On the other side of the door, Alice was still waiting for him to come to dinner.

But at the very moment he was about to step through the doorway, a faint sound caught his attention. It was the sudden rise in speed of the computer fan.

Zhou Ming stopped at once, pulled his foot back, and looked toward the sound.

On the faintly glowing computer screen, the error page that had shown “Network connection interrupted” and “Remote server not responding” was flickering. Then the error text suddenly vanished. Right after that, the loading bar at the bottom of the page turned from red to green and slowly began to move forward.

Zhou Ming felt his heart pound as if it were about to explode. A suffocating feeling spread through his lungs. The next second, he slammed the door shut and rushed back to his desk.

The loading bar at the bottom of the browser window was still moving. Its dim green looked like a slow, steady line of fire spreading forward. And on the blank page above, something was really appearing as it loaded.

It was an image.

Zhou Ming stared fixedly at the picture as it slowly came into view.

The Moon.

It looked like a direct photograph taken from somewhere in space. The image showed the Moon floating in the dark void. Its gray white surface was covered with craters and ravines, shaped like strange, light and dark markings. Even though he was no astronomy expert, Zhou Ming was deeply familiar with this classic image.

And once again he confirmed that the drawing he had seen in Tyrian’s office truly showed the Moon. The details were exactly the same. It was clearly the kind of picture only someone who had seen the Moon with their own eyes, up close, could have copied so precisely.

Zhou Ming slowly sank back into his chair and leaned against the backrest. His expression froze as he stared at the image of the Moon that almost filled the screen. After a long time, his gaze finally shifted upward to the line he had entered in the search box earlier:

“Does the world beyond the fog still exist?”

He stayed silent. After a long time, he suddenly woke up from his stone like state, grabbed the keyboard, and quickly typed new words into the search box:

“Is this the answer?”

“Who gave this answer?”

After quickly typing these two questions, Zhou Ming stared at the computer screen.

But no “one” replied. No new image or loading bar appeared on the screen. Only the cursor turned in place, stiff and mechanical, like a silent, dull eye. As the fan slowly dropped back to its low, soft whir, all he could hear by his ears once more were his own breathing and heartbeat.

A moment later, the image of the Moon vanished as the page refreshed after a failed load. The screen went pale again, leaving only one line of text:

“Network connection interrupted or remote server not responding.”

Chapter 511: Elven Food Culture

The door of the captain's cabin opened, and Duncan stepped inside. Goathead, who was in charge of the Vanished's course, reacted at once and turned his creaking wooden head toward him.

"Duncan Abnomar, I am answering in advance," Duncan said before the creature could speak. Then he walked straight to the liquor cabinet in the corner, poured himself a small glass of strong spirits, and downed it in one gulp.

The sharp, burning taste seared his nerves. The strong drink really did seem to have a calming effect. Duncan let out a light breath and felt his mood steady a little. Only then did he turn and walk to the enchanted sea chart, watching the plotted route stretch steadily toward the south.

Goathead's head slowly turned as Duncan moved, as if carefully watching the captain's every step. After a long while, it finally broke the silence, hesitantly: "Captain, you do not look to be in a very good mood… Do you need me to tell you a few cold jokes? I am especially good at elf style cold jokes. Many people think that race never smiles, but they actually have a special sense of humor. For example…"

"It has nothing to do with my mood, and I do not want to hear any cold jokes," Duncan said, waving his hand. He knew Goathead really wanted to help him relax, so he did not say anything more. He simply sat down quietly, as if fully focused on studying the lines and markers spreading across the enchanted sea chart.

But his thoughts could not help drifting.

In the end, he still did not get more answers in his small studio apartment. The computer in its strange state did not respond to any of the questions he entered afterward. It stayed as silent as ever, as if the sudden image of the Moon that had appeared earlier had been nothing more than his own illusion.

Yet even without more answers, Duncan had realized that he had truly touched that very important part.

The Moon from his home world had appeared in this eerie, twisted world. Even if it was only a “model”, a drawing, or even just a concept, it was enough to prove one thing.

The two worlds he had once thought were completely separate were not as clearly divided as he had believed.

But there was no one he could share these secrets with, no one who could analyze this with him. That included Alice, who trusted him without question, and Goathead, who looked so loyal on the desk.

Duncan let out a quiet breath and lifted his gaze. He saw Goathead still watching him, the onyx eyes in its wooden skull seeming to hold bottomless shadows.

“Captain, you can always trust your First Mate,” it said very seriously.

“I know, but not every problem is something you can help with,” Duncan said, shaking his head slightly. This time, though, his expression softened a little. “I appreciate it. But let us talk about this voyage instead. We are heading to an elven city-state in the south. How much do you know about the race called elves?”

“I still remember them…” Goathead spoke at once, as if the words had been waiting in its mind for some time, but it stalled right after it started. It

paused for quite a while before going on. “Ah, well, I did not have that much contact with them, but I know the elves have an excellent talent for mathematics and machinery. They also have a very unique historical legacy and some odd beliefs and customs. But more than that, they are best known for their strange understanding of ‘food’…”

“Their understanding of ‘food’?” Duncan frowned. “That sounds rather loaded.”

“Elven taste buds are different from those of other races, so they always make bold, local changes to any foreign food that reaches their city-state,” Goathead said in a very tactful tone. “So I wanted to remind Miss Nina before, and tell her not to have too high an expectation for the sweet pancakes of Lightwind Harbor. People do say that Lightwind Harbor brings together the signature dishes of many city-states in the civilized world, but no one ever explains how the elves mix those foods together.”

Duncan: “…?”

“In short, elves will stuff chili peppers and old fermented cheese that has started to bubble into the sweet pancakes,” Goathead went on. “In the end they create a flavor that shakes the soul. Personally, I think it is quite creative, and at least more normal than honeyed pig intestines and sour and spicy sheep eye pie.”

Duncan listened with a blank face. After a long moment he slowly said, “It seems Nina is going to be disappointed in the southern trip…”

…

Lucretia sat in Taran Ael’s laboratory, watching the famous elven scholar on the other side of the desk as he flipped rapidly through a pile of papers stacked like a small mountain, all while stuffing an egg wrap into his mouth with a blank face and wolfing it down.

The shocking smell of the egg wrap kept assaulting the Sea Witch's nerves.

It was a traditional elven convenience food, made mainly from flatbread, eggs, fermented cheese, and a kind of fungus called "black finger mushroom". It smelled a bit like badly rotted wood, and tasted like it too. After pickling, the black finger mushrooms had the awful texture and odor of an old rag. To Lucretia, it hardly counted as food at all.

But it was Master Taran Ael's favorite, not only because it suited elven tastes, but because it was quick and easy to eat. A Grand Scholar who was not afraid of dropping dead could finish a meal with it in three minutes. Eating three of them a day covered the basics of nutrition, and all the time saved could be poured into endless research and into matching wits with the doctors.

"Oh, found it. I knew it had to be here…"

Taran Ael finally shoved the last bite of egg wrap into his mouth. As he struggled to swallow, he spoke around the food and carefully pulled a bound stack of papers out from the swaying "mountain". The pile wobbled under his hands and looked ready to collapse, but in the end it settled again in a position that seemed even more dangerous than before.

"Here you are, Lady Lucretia, the material you asked for about the ancient kingdom of Critt and its link to Vision 001. If you had come to me yesterday, I would have found it at once. Back then I had not stuffed it into this 'mountain' yet…"

Lucretia took the stack of notes and could not help glancing again at the elven scholar across from her. By age, Taran Ael was in the "golden period" for an elf. He had just entered middle age, and with a little care he would no doubt have been a refined scholar who could charm countless maidens. But his habit of working to the point of forgetting sleep and food had completely ruined all that.

Most of the time, for example right now, this elven Master's image was all huge eye bags and dark circles, hair that was a mess and shedding every day. It had once been golden, but now its color and texture were closer to yellowed dry straw. His complexion was terrible.

Lucretia had worried more than once that this Grand Scholar would drop dead right in front of her, but luckily, or unbelievably, Master Taran Ael was still stubbornly alive today.

"I very, very strongly suggest you pay attention to your health and try to build at least a slightly normal routine," the Sea Witch sighed, flipping through the pages in her hands as she could not help speaking. "Even if it is only so you can live longer and keep doing research, you should take care of your body."

"I do pay attention," Taran Ael said casually, then carefully corrected himself. "I mean, at least more than before. But special times call for special standards, Lady Lucretia. You know what the fragments that fell from Vision 001 mean for the civilized world. We have to uncover its secrets, and the sooner the better…"

"But it is obvious we have hit a bottleneck now. Until a new breakthrough appears, your 'forgetting to eat and sleep' looks more like wasted effort," Lucretia said, lifting her eyelids. "Unless we can find someone from the ancient kingdom of Critt, or a manual that explains exactly how Vision 001 came into being, I still suggest you take a few days off."

Taran Ael waved his hand irritably, as if he wanted to argue but could not find any good reason to refute her. After a few seconds of sullen silence, something suddenly occurred to him. He looked up with a trace of hesitation and said: "Lady Lucretia, as far as I know… your father is on his way here, and he is coming for that 'fallen relic', is he not?"

“Yes. As soon as he heard about the ‘Visitor from Beyond the Sky’, he set off at once. He seems to take this matter extremely seriously,” Lucretia said, her expression a bit awkward. “I was completely unprepared for that. In fact, I still am not ready for it. But why are you bringing this up now?”

“Your father hurried here as soon as he learned of the ‘fallen relic’, so he clearly knows something, Lady Lucretia. Do you think… he might be the breakthrough we need? Maybe he knows what the stone sphere at the center of that luminous geometric body really is. Maybe he knows the exact connection between the ancient kingdom of Critt and Vision 001, or even…”

“Master Taran Ael,” Lucretia cut him off, “you may be misunderstanding something. My father is an outstanding explorer. What interests him might only be the ‘strange object’ itself. And please do not forget, he spent a century in Subspace. Even my elder brother and I have to be extremely cautious when we deal with Father. Your attitude right now is a bit too… optimistic and bold.”

Taran Ael laughed. “Ah, then which do you think has a higher chance of killing me: an unhealthy lifestyle, or boldly getting close to your father?”

The corner of Lucretia’s eye twitched. She opened her mouth, about to say something, but before she could, a sudden burst of shouting and exclamations from outside the window cut her off.

“The Sun! The Sun has gone out!”

Chapter 512

The shouts coming from the street outside made Lucretia and Taran Ael pause at the same time. A moment later, they both snapped their gazes toward the window.

Warm, bright sunlight was still pouring in from outside, so in the first few seconds neither Lucretia nor Taran Ael noticed anything wrong with the environment. But very soon, they realized that the sunlight spilling through the window felt off compared to before, and the overall brightness of the sky outside had already dimmed.

Lucretia’s eyes narrowed. In the next second she burst apart with a soft bang into countless fluttering scraps of colored paper that whirled out through the window. The paper fragments spun like a whirlwind up to the roof, where they gathered again on a small platform and reshaped into the figure of the sea witch.

Lucretia raised her head and looked toward the place where the Sun should have been hanging high in the sky.

A gigantic Dark Sphere was floating silently up there. Two rune rings ran along its edge, shedding blinding golden radiance. Between those two circles of light, dim gaps kept flickering like a lamp with a loose connection, as if everything might go completely dark at any moment.

With the main luminous body plunged into darkness, the only brightness left from the Sun now came from those two rune rings. In theory, the whole city-state should already have been as dim as late evening.

Yet sunlight still bathed Lightwind Harbor. That light came from the sea not far away. The mountain-like glowing geometric body was still quietly floating on the ocean. Pale golden sunlight drifted out from that direction, keeping the city from falling into darkness. It was this light that Lucretia and Taran Ael had seen earlier in their room.

The sound of fabric scraping against stone and ragged breathing reached Lucretia's ears. She lowered her head and saw a middle?aged elf with messy short blond hair struggling up along a drainpipe.

Master Taran Ael, dragging a century's worth of shoulder and neck problems with him, had finally climbed up onto the platform.

The talent of elves was truly awe?inspiring.

"Huff… huff… Lady Lucretia, you were right… huff… I might really need a bit of exercise. Just paying attention to nutrition isn't… huff… enough to stay strong…"

"I don't believe you've been paying attention to nutrition at all. The Vital-Signs Ration only keeps your vital signs going," Lucretia said calmly. Her face stayed expressionless, but her eyes were still fixed on the Dark Sphere hanging high in the distant sky. "For now, you should look at the sky first. That problem is bigger."

Taran Ael finally caught his breath and lifted his head to look in that direction.

Under the slanting pale golden glow spreading from the sea, the Dark Sphere hanging up there looked even more eerie. Visions 001 – the Sun, which had protected this world for ten thousand years, looked terrifying after it went dark.

It was like a dreadful void that led to the End of all things, or like a dying eyeball full of rot, quietly gazing down at the entire world from the sky.

“…Oh. This looks serious…” A few words finally squeezed out of Taran Ael’s throat. His eyes, bloodshot from years of working late into the night, slowly narrowed as if he wanted to focus and see more detail on the surface of the Dark Sphere. “The worst kind of thing…”

“The city-state Guard Corps has already started maintaining order. It seems all that mechanical training day after day was good for something.” Lucretia lowered her head and looked at the streets below. Steam Walkers and tactical squads bearing the emblems of the Guard Corps and Truth Academy had already appeared at the intersections. Panicked citizens were slowly regaining control under mental guidance. Even so, the overall chaos in the district continued, and no one knew how far it would go.

Everyone in this world was always preparing for “eerie disasters”. But no matter what, the extinguishing of the Sun clearly shook ordinary people far beyond anything their drills and plans had imagined.

“I’m going back to the Radiant Star to confirm the situation,” Lucretia suddenly pulled her gaze away from the streets and quickly turned to Taran Ael. “That ship is near the falling glowing orb. It might be able to collect useful data.”

Taran Ael opened his mouth when he heard this, but before he could say anything, the sea witch in front of him had once again burst into a cloud of colorful paper scraps. In the blink of an eye they whirled off the rooftop platform and flew toward the distant harbor.

The elven Grand Scholar was simply left standing on the roof. He stared blankly for a moment, then lowered his head to look back at the direction he had just climbed up from.

“You could at least have carried me back down…”

He grumbled in frustration, slowly straightened up, and prepared to climb back down the drainpipe to the second?floor balcony. But just then, something at the edge of his vision caught his eye.

It was a nearby building: the Tower of Flowing Clouds at the city-state university. It was property of the Truth Academy, and most elves simply called it “the high tower”.

Various observation devices were mounted on top of that tower to monitor the weather and watch the sky. With its special filters and telescopes, it could even observe the Sun and other faraway objects.

“…Observing the Sun at a time like this doesn’t sound very wise…”

The elven Grand Scholar muttered this under his breath. Then he casually took a charm amulet of Rahm, God of Wisdom, from inside his coat. He pressed it to his forehead in a brief benediction, praying for the blessing of foolishness.

“All right, now I’m a fool.”

Taran Ael put the charm amulet away, took a deep breath, then quickly judged the distances and positions of the nearby rooftops. He sprinted toward the one he thought he had the best chance of reaching and leaped.

In the two seconds when he briefly broke free from gravity, felt the wind on his cheeks, and flew over the rooftop, a very valuable question suddenly rose in the mind of this elven Grand Scholar:

[Why didn’t I call my own student to help?]

…

The whole world fell into dimness. A strange daylight like dusk, but heavier and more oppressive than dusk, covered the Boundless Sea.

The extinguished giant sphere hung in the sky like a terrible void. Ever since it went dark, it had not moved again. Two rune structures circled it and shed the last “afterglow”. With the Sun extinguished, those two rings of light were almost harsh to look at.

Yet when that “blinding” light shone down on the mortal world, it could only barely drive back the darkness.

Duncan stepped onto the deck and looked up with a particularly grave expression, turning his gaze on that pitch?black sphere. He said nothing.

Everyone else had rushed out of their cabins and gathered on the deck to stare at the strange sky. Vanna was whispering a prayer. Morris frowned deeply. Shirley clutched Dog tight and hid behind Duncan. Nina held onto Duncan’s arm, her face full of panic and nervousness.

Pale golden light was already faintly rising and falling in Nina’s eyes.

Only Alice showed an unbelievable kind of “calm”. One hand on her head, she tilted her face back and stared curiously at the extinguished Sun, as if she had just discovered something new and strange. She did not look scared at all.

Lacking common sense, she seemed unable to fully understand what was happening.

A trembling mass of shadows suddenly appeared in the air near Duncan. The Shadows rapidly swelled, shrank, and gathered, forming the outline of Agatha.

“The Spirit Realm is normal, Captain,” she said quickly to Duncan. “There’s nothing wrong with the rest of the ship either.”

Duncan gave a slight nod.

As a mirror world, Agatha could move freely through the world of mirrors. She could check every cabin on the Vanished in an instant. She also had “eyes” that could see into the Spirit Realm and could constantly confirm the state of the deep layers around the Vanished. Many times, the information she observed was even more complete than what Duncan could sense.

“Captain…” Shirley hugged Dog’s head and looked up at Duncan. The face that was usually full of silly grins was now filled with fear and panic. “What’s going on… Is this what you warned us about before?”

Duncan did not answer her immediately. Instead, he frowned and studied the sky carefully. After a long while, he finally spoke in a low voice, almost to himself: “The World’s Wound hasn’t appeared.”

“The World’s Wound?” Morris, standing nearby, froze when he heard this. Then he reacted and raised his head to look at the sky. “You’re right. The World’s Wound is still hidden. That means…”

“The Sun is still working,” Duncan said with a slight nod. “Only its ‘light? emitting’ function has shut down for some reason. Its suppression of the World’s Wound is still in place.”

“Then… will the Sun light up again?” Alice suddenly turned her head and asked curiously.

Duncan had no answer.

Even so, he still nodded a little. “It should. This vast Visions system has run steadily for ten thousand years. Even if something went wrong, it shouldn’t suddenly collapse completely. At least… it shouldn’t be today.”

Alice relaxed and smiled happily. “Oh, that’s good. My quilt hasn’t finished drying yet.”

Hearing this thoughtless doll say that, Duncan couldn’t help but let out a small laugh. Then he lowered his head and ruffled Nina’s hair.

Nina looked up. Pale golden flames burned in her pupils, and the radiance of a star brewed within that fire.

She gave a small nod, then let go of Duncan’s arm.

A moment later, dazzling light suddenly surged up from the deck. In an instant, Nina turned into an arcing blaze. This shrunken solar prominence circled Duncan twice, leaping and dancing, then lightly hopped onto the mast, flew into the sky, and finally came to rest above the tallest mast of the Vanished, hovering steadily tens of meters above the top.

The arc of flame coiled there. Its fire gathered into a tiny blazing sun. sunlight once more poured down on the Vanished and on a small stretch of sea around it.

Far away in the sky, Visions 001 remained extinguished. But at least within the range illuminated by this “fragment of the Sun”, comforting warmth and light once again bathed everyone.

Duncan let out a quiet breath. He knew that, in a situation like this, light steadied people’s hearts more than anything.

“All right. Now I should go check what’s happening elsewhere.”

Chapter 513

In Pland, the extinguishing of the Sun naturally threw the entire city into chaos. But before the chaos grew truly dangerous, the city-state Guard Corps and the Guardian troops arrived in time and brought the situation under control.

The deep, mellow chimes of the small cathedral’s bells echoed over the streets. It was as if the bell?tones carried a power that calmed hearts and restored courage. Steam Walkers clanked through alleys and along main roads. Loudspeakers on their hulls broadcast the latest orders from City Hall. Gas lamps on both sides of the streets were lit in a rush. Panicked pedestrians did everything they could to hurry back to the safety of their own homes, or to dive into the nearest veil of night shelter.

Heavily armed Guardians moved swiftly through the crowds. They checked on the veil of night shelters one by one and searched the sudden darkness for any “filth” that should not appear in the Mortal Realm.

Heidi switched on every light in her home the instant she could. From gas lamps and oil lamps with holy power to bright electric lamps, she used every bit of light she had to drive away the darkness left by the Sun’s extinction—and to drive away the tension in her heart.

Her mother’s voice came from the sofa: “Relax a little, Heidi. You’ll trip if you keep running around. The world’s Doomsday hasn’t arrived yet.”

Heidi turned and saw her mother sitting on the sofa just as always. The old woman had already picked up the letters she had set aside for a moment

when the darkness suddenly fell. Her expression was still gentle and calm, as if nothing that happened in this world could really affect her.

“The Sun has gone out! That’s not a small thing!” Heidi was shocked by how calm her mother was. She herself could not settle down at all. “You can still read letters right now?”

“If I put the letters down, will the Sun light up again?” Mother finally turned her head. A helpless look crossed her face. “Right now all we can do is trust City Hall and the Great Cathedral. There will be mighty beings watching over this city.”

Heidi pressed her lips together and unconsciously tightened her grip on the pendant hanging at her chest. “Damn it… If only Vanna were here. I could ask her what’s really going on… and Father isn’t home either…”

She did not notice the subtle expression that flashed across her mother’s face when she heard these muttered complaints.

The next second, the old woman shook her head.

“If the Sun really has gone out, then it’s something the whole world can see. Vanna and your father must have seen it too. They’re surely doing everything they can within their own duties. And you… you should calm down and think about your own duty now.”

Heidi finally began to settle. She frowned slightly and turned her gaze toward the nearby table.

A fine, sturdy medical case sat quietly in one corner of it.

It was filled with all the tools and medicines she used while practicing medicine. Because the city-state had been unusually calm at night for quite some time, she hadn’t needed to use the most potent things in the case for a long while.

“Many people will need mental counseling,” her mother’s soothing voice came from behind her. “I expect it won’t be long before City Hall sends someone to pick you up. The Sun has only dimmed for now. Our city hasn’t sunk.”

Heidi let out a soft breath and walked slowly toward her medical case. “All right, you’re right. The world’s Doomsday hasn’t come yet—so my overtime isn’t over either.”

“When you go out on calls, don’t forget to take your gun,” Mother reminded her gently. “Pland these days is much safer than it used to be, but the mentally broken are always dangerous. When you have to, you must use drastic means on the ‘lesion’.”

“Of course.” Heidi answered without thinking. She opened a hidden compartment at the bottom of the case. A finely crafted revolver and several spare cylinders lay quietly inside. After a quick check of the weapon, she couldn’t help sighing a little. “After all… gunpowder is also medicine.”

…

“I’ve already sent out the city-state Guard Corps. For now, we don’t need to worry about order inside Frostholm,” Tyrian said. He stood by the large floor?to?ceiling mirror in the corner of his domed office, speaking to the glass with a serious face. “The tension from the recent mirror world crisis hasn’t faded yet. The good news is that under this tension, all the emergency plans can be carried out more quickly.”

ghostly green flame burned softly on the surface of the mirror like a sheer veil. Duncan’s figure stood in the darkness behind the glass. When Tyrian finished speaking, Duncan gave a slight nod.

“Good. Have there been any signs of something supernatural in the city?”

“Nothing so far,” Tyrian replied at once. “But I’ve already assigned more people to watch places like mental hospitals in particular. The Great Cathedral is also sending people to patrol the veil of night Sanctuary Worlds, the cemeteries, and the districts where there isn’t much light…”

“In theory, within the Visions-altered Frostholm, darkness itself is no longer a dangerous factor. The only things we need to watch closely are mental collapse and widespread panic,” Duncan reminded him. “Also, you don’t need to send anyone to the cemeteries. I’ll watch that area myself.”

“Yes,” Tyrian said quickly. Then he hesitated, choosing his words with care. “How are things on your side? Nothing has gone wrong on the Vanished, has it?”

“There’s nothing here that can threaten the Vanished,” Duncan said calmly. “Nina has already lit a temporary Sun in the sky. We’re still sailing south as planned. The surrounding sea… is calmer than I expected.”

Tyrian quietly let out a breath. “Then it seems I was worrying too much.”

“Can you still reach Lightwind Harbor?” Duncan’s voice came again from the mirror. “What’s the situation with Lucretia?”

“I just contacted her. She’s just returned to the Radiant Star. There are no safety problems at the moment,” Tyrian said at once. “She said they also saw the Sun go out over Lightwind Harbor, but the chaos in that city-state is much milder than here in Frostholm. Because of that mysterious fallen relic, most of Lightwind Harbor is still covered in sunlight. The sky’s Visions are unsettling, but they don’t look as terrifying there as they do here.”

“That’s good. Stay in contact and keep a close eye on changes inside the city-state.”

“Yes,” Tyrian nodded again. After another moment’s hesitation, he slowly went on, “There’s one more situation…”

“Speak,” Duncan said with a frown in the mirror. “At a time like this, you should speak of anything.”

“…We’ve lost contact with the other city-states. All of them,” Tyrian said carefully. “Both the ones far away and those close by, like Cold Harbor. The telegraph has gone silent. The signal towers at sea aren’t responding. Even the Cathedral’s Psychic Communication can’t reach them. At present, only two city-states are barely still in touch with us: Pland and Lightwind Harbor.”

“Lost contact with the other city-states?” Duncan’s expression grew even more serious. “How long has this been going on?”

“We noticed the breakdown in communication with Cold Harbor as soon as the Sun went out. After that, we confirmed that it was the same with the other city-states,” Tyrian answered quickly. “I’ve urgently recalled every ship in the waters near Frostholm and banned all vessels from sailing out.”

As he spoke, there were still some words he did not say aloud. Ever since communications with the other city-states had broken down, a strange, heavy worry had pressed on his heart. He feared that beyond the city-states, in those parts of the Boundless Sea where sunlight no longer shone, the ocean had already turned into something people could no longer understand…

“Keep trying to reach the other city-states,” Duncan’s voice from the mirror cut off Tyrian’s thoughts. “And if there’s any new information from Lucy, contact me immediately.”

“Yes, Father.”

The communication with the Vanished ended, and the vast domed office fell quiet again.

Tyrian raised a hand and rubbed his aching brow hard.

Then he pressed the bell on his desk.

The office door opened and Aiden walked in.

Tyrian looked up and gave an order to his most loyal subordinate:

“Keep a close eye on any ships returning from the dark. Until the Sun lights up again, don’t let them approach the city-state rashly. mark out a ‘buffer zone’ in the Nearshore Waters. Have the returning ships wait there for inspection and clearance.”

…

The mirror in front of Duncan slowly grew calm again. The ghostly green flame retreated for now to a corner along the frame. Duncan let out a quiet breath and turned his head to look out the window.

Brilliant sunlight still shone on the deck of the Vanished and over a broad stretch of sea around it. But beyond the reach of that sunlight, the Boundless Sea remained drowned in an eerie, absolute darkness.

It was a deeply unsettling time. Even Goathead, usually the noisiest presence on board, lay silent on the enchanted sea chart table.

Only Alice was still happily spreading quilts out to dry on the deck…

Duncan rubbed his forehead, trying hard not to pay attention to the figure busy with the quilts. He focused his mind instead and silently called to the flame hovering in the sky.

“Nina, how are things up there? Are you tired?”

“Not tired at all.” Thanks to the resonance of the Power of Flame, Nina’s voice rang in Duncan’s mind almost at once. “I’m not very high up. I can stay here for a very, very long time!”

“Can you see anything on the sea around us?”

“Mm… no. There’s nothing at all on the sea around us. Not even a little wind or waves. Uncle Duncan, did you think of something?”

“Nothing for now. But keep watching the sea at all times—especially the waters at the boundary between light and dark,” Duncan said slowly. “If any ships or anything like that appear nearby, tell me immediately.”

Nina answered at once: “Okay!”

Duncan made a soft sound in his throat and ended the link with Nina. Then he looked at the mirror in front of him, steadied himself a little, and reached out to brush the surface.

“Lawrence, how are things on your side?”

Chapter 514: Lighting Up

After the Sun went out, its remaining faint glow hung high in the sky. That weak light could not brighten the sea. It only made the whole world look even darker and more frightening.

The White Oak sailed through the depths of this darkness.

Lights on the ship were already on. The glow of oil lamps and electric fixtures mingled and spread out, lighting up a small patch of sea nearby. The small waves rose and fell in that weak light and somehow looked thick and ominous.

Lawrence held the wheel and answered the voice in his mind: "…The White Oak is still in good shape here. Aside from the sailors being a little nervous, nothing has gone wrong on board. But the area around us has fallen into darkness, and we have lost contact with the other ships on the route. Navigation has also failed, and the Stargazing Room can only see pitch black."

Duncan's voice echoed directly in his mind: "Can you reach Cold Harbor, the closest city-state to you? You should have left that city-state not long ago."

"No," Lawrence said. He glanced back at the communications console not far away and saw that all the lights on the machine were red. "All communications are down. The priest tried to use Psychic Resonance to reach Cold Harbor's Cathedral, but there was no response—only the Psychic Resonance with Pland is barely holding."

“Pland is fine, and Frostholm is also all right. Right now, aside from Frostholm, Pland, and Lightwind Harbor, we have lost contact with every other city-state. It feels… as if they all vanished after the Sun went out.”

Hearing Captain Duncan’s description, Lawrence’s expression slowly tightened. He swallowed hard, as if afraid to keep imagining what it might mean.

Then he lowered his head and glanced at the instrument panel beside the wheel, quickly checking each reading.

“We are sailing at full speed toward Pland. This is a very busy route. In theory, we should soon see a relay port—that is an island under the city-state of Lunsa. We will check the situation there and report to you at once…”

Lawrence spoke quickly in his mind, but before he finished, a sudden rush of footsteps cut off what he was about to say.

A crew member ran into the bridge in a panic: “Captain! Captain! You need to come see this! That ‘Sailor’ found something big!”

“Anomaly077?” Lawrence’s expression tightened at once. He turned to the First Mate beside him: “Gus, take the wheel. I’ll go take a look!”

Gus stepped forward at once: “Yes, Captain!”

Lawrence left the bridge in a hurry. Led by the crew member, he rushed down the stairs and through the corridors to the aft deck of the White Oak. As soon as he arrived, he saw a thin, shriveled figure busily moving along the edge of the stern deck.

Anomaly077, that bizarre living mummified corpse, was fiddling with something beside a huge iron barrel. He worked while muttering nonstop. Lawrence walked closer before he finally heard what the corpse kept muttering: “We’re done, we’re done, we’re finished this time. No one is

getting away, no one is going back. The whole world is doomed. I might as well just sleep myself to death…”

This guy was overflowing with negative energy as always.

Lawrence did not want to hear Anomaly077 mutter any longer. He strode forward in two quick steps and cut him off loudly: “What are you doing?”

The mummified corpse jolted, as if waking from a dream, and quickly bowed and nodded: “Captain! Captain, you’re here… Oh, good, now that the Captain is here, everything feels safer…”

“Enough, enough,” Lawrence waved his hand and asked again, “What exactly are you doing?”

“You have to see this, you have to look at this…” the mummified corpse said in a panic. He hurried over to the iron barrel and stirred inside with a big pair of tongs. A thick, oily sound came from within.

Only now did Lawrence see that the barrel was full of fuel. Anomaly077 was using the tongs to stir a rag in the grease. Then the mummified corpse lifted out the oil-soaked wad of cloth, pulled out a lighter he had somehow gotten from a crew member, and lit the cloth.

Under Lawrence’s frowning gaze, Anomaly077 hurled the burning rag out toward the sea. The fireball hit the surface and, carried by the waves, quickly drifted toward the rear of the White Oak.

Anomaly077 muttered: “This is how sailors used to roughly measure speed —back before you people invented all those fancy instruments. It isn’t very accurate, but it’s useful…”

“I know. I’ve read about this,” Lawrence cut him off. “But what exactly do you want me to see?”

Sailor waved his hands hard and pointed into the distance: “Just keep watching. It’s almost there. Keep your eyes on that flame drifting away…”

Lawrence frowned and turned his head, staring at the flame floating on the sea. It was rapidly drifting toward the stern of the White Oak, which was only natural. The White Oak was moving at full speed, so there was nothing strange about it.

Until the flame suddenly stopped in the distance.

Lawrence’s gaze sharpened at once.

That fireball, which should have kept drifting away until the waves swallowed it or it passed beyond the limit of sight, stopped out there.

By a rough estimate, that spot was only a few hundred meters from the White Oak.

Lawrence stared hard in that direction, watching the flame that had stopped a few hundred meters behind the White Oak. It looked as if the fire was sailing at the same speed as the White Oak, following right behind it. Only after a long time did the flame slowly dim and finally go out at the edge of the dark water.

Sailor picked up another rag with the tongs, soaked it in oil, lit it, and threw it into the water.

The second ball of fire hit the water, quickly drifted backward, and then stopped at the same distance.

Anomaly077 finally tossed the tongs aside. He turned to look at Lawrence, his thin, ghastly face twisting into a miserable expression: “Captain, look… How are we supposed to explain this with science?”

This time, Lawrence did not tease this “Anomaly” for being obsessed with explaining everything with science like he usually did. He simply stood

quietly at the edge of the deck. After a long while, he seemed to murmur to himself: “Did you see that?”

Anomaly077 beside him froze for a second: “Huh? Who are you talking to?”

Lawrence did not answer. Instead, Duncan’s deep, solemn voice sounded in his mind: “I saw it. I saw it very clearly through your shared sight.”

“How… do you see this phenomenon?” Lawrence asked carefully.

“The laws of physics are becoming strange. It is very likely some kind of ‘distortion’ in the field of space, or perhaps something deeper in the deep layers. In any case, after sunlight went out, the Boundless Sea began changing rapidly—and only the White Oak and the small area around it are still normal for now.”

Lawrence thought for a moment, then spoke hesitantly: “Is this your power at work…?”

“Perhaps. But I also need time to figure out the cause.”

Listening to the voice in his mind and staring at the dark, chaotic sea in the distance, Lawrence fell into deep thought.

Right then, a strange, low sound broke his thoughts. It seemed to come from the sky, yet also echoed through the whole world.

It was a weird, sluggish hum, like a giant beast struggling to breathe, or some unimaginably huge device slowly starting up. It sounded faint and far away, yet also seemed to fill the whole world, echoing in everyone’s ears.

Lawrence looked up in shock at the extinguished Sun.

The double rune rings around the Sun were flickering, their light rising and falling. As the rune rings flickered, faint threads of radiance slowly appeared on the Dark Sphere at the center of Visions001.

Those thin strands of light were at first weak and reddish, like veins of blood. Then they began to spread over the whole sphere and quickly grew bright…

…

The huge glowing geometric body floated above the sea. The even sunlight it released shone over Lightwind Harbor not far away, and over the Radiant Star moored by the floating docks.

On the highest research platform of the Radiant Star, Lucretia stared intently at the large circular crystal lens before her.

A faint blue glow floated around the crystal lens, while the center of the lens showed bands of shifting color, bright and dark.

The clockwork doll Lunie stood near Lucretia. As she adjusted the dizzying array of observation instruments with her precise, nimble hands, she reported to her Mistress: “Starting just now, there have been these strange ‘signals’ mixed into the sunlight released by the glowing geometric body. They can’t be seen with the naked eye, but the ship’s observation lenses can catch them. What we see is this pattern of bright and dark ripples that keep rising and falling…”

Lucretia raised her head and looked toward the front of the room. This research platform was enclosed, but there was a special window at the far end. sunlight from the glowing geometric body passed through that window into the room, then went through a complex lens array device. In the end it was split into Spectral Charts and projected onto special observation equipment. She had designed and built this entire system herself.

It was a large apparatus she had built specifically to study the glowing geometric body—and now it was doing its job.

Lucretia looked back and glanced at the Recording Engine on the table beside her. The machine was steadily feeding out a long strip of paper. On that paper, the changes in the spectrum captured by the lens system were recorded as jumping black lines with a clear, regular pattern.

“These ‘Light-Signals’ are patterned…” she said softly.

“Yes,” Lunie the doll nodded. “Each group of signals has a sending period of twelve seconds. They repeat three times, then pause for thirty seconds, and then appear again.”

“Are they being sent from that ‘stone sphere’?”

“It’s hard to say. People from the Truth Academy are monitoring the area around the stone sphere, but they haven’t seen any changes in the sphere itself. These Light-Signals seem more like they are appearing out of thin air in the bright region around the sphere…”

Lunie the doll stopped halfway through her sentence.

“Mistress, the Light-Signals have stopped.”

Lucretia stared in surprise at the crystal lens in front of her.

Those bright and dark, shifting colors had vanished.

She was dazed for a moment. Then she seemed to think of something. Her figure suddenly broke apart and turned into a storm of colorful paper slips that whirled out through the window.

The colored paper slips fluttered above the deck and quickly gathered together again. Lucretia stood on the upper deck of the Radiant Star, narrowed her eyes, and looked up at the sky.

Through the pale golden sunlight spread over the sea, she saw an especially bright glowing orb hanging high in the sky.

The Sun had lit up again.

Chapter 515: After the Sun Rekindled

The Sun had lit up again.

After being extinguished for a full twelve hours, the Dark Sphere hanging motionless in the sky once again became “the Sun” that brought warmth and light to this world, and it began to move again.

In Pland, in Frostholm, in Lightwind Harbor, everyone who had seen the Sun go out now saw Visions001 restored again.

However, the terror caused by the Sun’s extinction did not fade so easily. Residents in the city-states were still uneasy. Scholars and priests looked at the relit Sun with the same confusion and tension they had felt when they watched it go out. The cities’ administrators were still trying to confirm the situation in other cities. Everyone was desperate to know—what had happened?

The swirling colored paper swept across the deck like a gust of wind, passed through a window, and fell into the captain’s cabin. Lucretia’s figure gathered from the paper slips. She stepped up to her scrying crystal, activated it, and waited a little anxiously for the reply from the other side.

As soon as Tyrian’s image appeared, she spoke quickly: “I can see that the Sun has lit up again from here. What is it like on your side?”

“Of course it has here too. At least for now, it looks like we are still looking at the same Sun,” Tyrian said. There was a hint of fatigue in his eyes, but he

still seemed in good shape. “I may need some time before I can calm the mood in the city. Right now everyone is afraid the sky above their heads will fall into darkness again…”

“…The Sun is a symbol of safety. It has sheltered our days for ten thousand years without change. In other words, once it goes out even once, the most basic, solid sense of ‘safety’ in everyone’s hearts is badly damaged,” Lucretia sighed and voiced what she was thinking. “No one can help worrying about it. Not even me.”

“Did you gather any useful information while the Sun was out?” Tyrian asked. “You have all kinds of instruments over there…”

Lucretia nodded at once: “Yes. After the Sun went out, a set of observation devices I set up on the Radiant Star received strange signals coming from inside that ‘glowing geometric body’. Once I sort out the data, I’ll send you a copy. See if the scholars in Frostholm can make anything of it. Later, I also need to go to Lightwind Harbor again and check whether the monitoring devices the Truth Academy placed around the city found anything…”

“All right. I’ll wait for your news.”

Lucretia made a small sound of assent. Then she hesitated for a few seconds before speaking: “How is Father? He was still at sea when the Sun went out…”

“I’ve been in touch with him the whole time. Everything on the Vanished is normal, maybe even… better than in the city,” Tyrian let out a breath. “I’ll contact him again later. Don’t worry. If I sense anything wrong… I’ll tell you at once.”

Lucretia nodded lightly. After saying goodbye to her Big Brother, she casually extinguished the scrying crystal in front of her.

…

On the Vanished, in the captain’s cabin, the image of Lawrence, captain of the White Oak, appeared in the Oval Scrying Mirror before Duncan. Lawrence was reporting the latest situation:

“The sea around the White Oak has returned to normal. That strange phenomenon hasn’t appeared again. It seems that as the Sun lit up again, everything started going back on track…”

“How is navigation?”

“The Stargazing Room can see the ‘Starry Sky’ again,” Lawrence said with a quick nod. “But the Spirit Realm lenses still need some time to recalibrate. For now, we can roughly tell that the White Oak has not drifted too far off course.”

“Good. Report to me at once if anything else happens.”

The illusory spirit form flames around the edge of the mirror rose and fell, and Lawrence’s image in the mirror slowly faded. Duncan still stood before the now-normal mirror, frowning in thought.

The Sun had recovered. The situation was more or less what he had first expected. Visions001 was indeed having problems, but this huge, ancient “device” would not fully collapse in a short time. It might keep going for a long while yet, through repeated failures and repairs. Today’s extinction was only temporary—and, in the same way, its rekindling was also temporary.

More than the Sun’s brief extinction, what Duncan cared about now were the other things: the strange phenomena that had happened after the Sun went out.

The first strange phenomenon was the loss of contact with every city-state except Pland, Lightwind Harbor, and Frostholm.

If all communication across the Boundless Sea had gone down, it would have been less troubling. But three city-states had stayed normal. If Pland and Frostholm were special because they had become “Visions”, then what about Lightwind Harbor?

The second strange phenomenon was even more puzzling than the “lost communication”: what exactly was that “boundary” the White Oak had observed?

A burning bundle of cloth thrown from the ship into the sea should, in theory, keep drifting away in the direction opposite the ship’s course. Yet while the Sun was out, those bundles all “stopped” near some “boundary” after drifting only a few hundred meters…

And according to Lawrence’s report just now, once the Sun lit up again, this strange phenomenon vanished as well. The mummified corpse “Sailor” had run several more tests to confirm it.

Duncan furrowed his brows tightly.

The phenomenon the White Oak had observed was actually tiny in scale. Compared to the “loss of contact” across all the city-states on the Boundless Sea, that “boundary” was limited to the space around a single ship. But what lay behind that phenomenon seemed far beyond imagination.

Vaguely, Duncan felt he had brushed against some crucial “secret” of the Boundless Sea. The “true face” of this whole world seemed to be hidden in those twelve hours after the Sun went out.

Just then, a call from far away suddenly broke his train of thought.

Duncan came back to himself at once and glanced over the mirror before him.

In the next second, the translucent spirit form flames once again wrapped around the mirror. The depths of the mirror turned pitch-black, and Tyrian’s

figure appeared within.

“Father, over there you…”

“Everything is fine here. The Sun has recovered, hasn’t it?” Duncan cut him off before he could finish. “How is Frostholm?”

“Everything is fine here in Frostholm,” Tyrian answered at once. “With you ‘watching over’ the cemetery, the pressure on the Church and City Hall has dropped a lot. Order across the city is under control now, but the citizens’ fear will need time to calm. I’ll call a meeting later to discuss how to explain the Sun’s extinction to ordinary people…”

Duncan noticed that while Tyrian spoke, he kept sneaking glances this way, as if… carefully watching for changes in Duncan’s expression.

He quickly understood why.

“Relax. I’m still me. I have not been swapped out for something from Subspace just because the Sun went out for a short while,” Duncan said with a calm smile, speaking the blunt truth. “If you don’t believe me, go to the cemetery and confirm it face-to-face with my ‘avatar form’?”

“Ah, no, I didn’t mean anything like that!” Tyrian explained in a rush. “It’s just… Lucy was a bit worried about you…”

“I know,” Duncan cut him off and waved casually. “But you can relax. My mental health is perfectly fine. Instead of worrying about me, tell me about the city. Has communication with the other city-states been restored?”

“We can receive signals from Cold Harbor now, and Psychic Communication with other distant city-states has also been restored,” Tyrian said with a nod. “I’ve already sent people to ask about the situation in each city-state. We should soon…”

He stopped suddenly at that point, and his gaze shifted to the side.

It seemed someone had entered the domed office and was reporting something to him.

Duncan did not speak. He immediately withdrew his gaze and hid the link between the mirrors. This was to avoid frightening the “ordinary person” on that side.

After a few minutes, the flames around the edge of the mirror burned up again. Duncan heard Tyrian calling him and turned his gaze back to the mirror.

Tyrian’s image appeared in the mirror again, and this time he clearly still looked stunned.

Duncan noticed the change in his expression and frowned slightly: “What happened?”

“We… just got in touch with Cold Harbor and asked about what happened in their city-state while the Sun was out,” Tyrian said slowly, as if weighing every word. “They were very surprised. They have no idea that the Sun ever went out!”

Duncan’s expression hardened at once.

After more than ten seconds, he seemed to think of something and broke the silence in a grave tone: “Be clear. Is it that the people in Cold Harbor never saw the Sun go out? Or is it that they never experienced those twelve hours at all?”

Tyrian froze for a moment, then quickly grasped what Duncan meant.

“You mean…”

“Confirm it again. See whether Cold Harbor has any record of a break in communication with Frostholm. If, in their view, the whole world was

always normal and their link with Frostholm was never cut… then this is much more complicated than we thought.”

“Yes, I’ll check at once,” Tyrian said quickly. “And I’ll confirm with the other city-states one by one!”

Duncan nodded and waved away the flickering flames around the mirror. Just as he was about to think this through, Goathead’s startled shout suddenly came from not far away: “Captain! Something’s not right! Come take a look at the enchanted sea chart!”

“enchanted sea chart?”

Puzzled, Duncan turned and quickly walked over to the chart table. His eyes swept over the eerie enchanted sea chart, wreathed in mist.

In the next second, he saw the projection of the Vanished on the enchanted sea chart and… a city-state marker slowly appearing beside that projection.

“We’re… near Lightwind Harbor?”

Chapter 516: Approaching

“At our current speed, we will reach the waters around Lightwind Harbor in a day. But that is only what the enchanted sea chart shows. As for whether the Vanished is actually in these waters right now, we still have to confirm it. After all… this is far too unbelievable.”

Goathead’s tone carried both gravity and hesitation, and ever since Duncan had met this thing, he had rarely heard it react like this.

There was no doubt that what was happening to the Vanished now had already gone far beyond this “First Mate’s” experience.

Duncan braced both hands on the edge of the chart table, his expression grave as he stared at the patch of slowly rippling mist on the enchanted sea chart. Between the pale outline of the Vanished and the route to the north, swaths of mist now floated—this was the route the Vanished should have sailed along, yet it was still shrouded in fog.

“…During the twelve hours when the Sun went out, we directly ‘skipped’ the entire stretch of voyage from the northern route to the southern seas, and not even you know how it happened,” Duncan raised his eyes and looked at Goathead on the edge of the table. “But during that same period, the White Oak on the Boundless Sea did not experience this. They still more or less kept to the proper sailing path.”

“…I don’t know how to explain this, Captain,” Goathead’s head swayed slightly, looking embarrassed and uneasy. “The Vanished and the White Oak have both gone through your flame’s Baptism, but the two ships are far

too different. Any tiny difference in detail could be the reason this happened…”

Duncan did not speak for a moment. His face remained solemn as he sank into thought for more than ten seconds. Then he suddenly seemed to think of something and broke the silence: “When did the enchanted sea chart change?”

This time Goathead answered unusually fast: “Just now, when the Sun lit up again.”

“Are you sure?” Duncan knew the other would not lie to him, but he still asked out of habit.

“Positive,” Goathead nodded up and down. “I have been watching everything related to ‘navigation’, including any movement on the enchanted sea chart. While the Sun was out, the enchanted sea chart did not change at all, as if we were standing still. Only after the Sun lit up again did the enchanted sea chart start showing some… confusion. It was like the chaos we see every time we rise from the Spirit Realm back into the Mortal Realm. I thought it was just recalibrating itself, but when it finally stabilized, it showed that the Vanished was already near Lightwind Harbor…”

Duncan listened carefully to Goathead’s explanation. Suddenly he frowned: “So this ‘jump’ most likely happened at the very moment the Sun rekindled…”

Goathead slowly nodded.

The captain’s cabin fell into a heavy silence.

Duncan did not know what Goathead was thinking. He only knew that his own mind was full of chaotic guesses and countless questions, and all of

them seemed to circle one single core: during the Sun's extinction and rekindling, what exactly had changed in the Boundless Sea?

At first, he had only thought it was a temporary darkness, just like when the Sun had risen more than ten minutes late before. During that delayed sunrise, aside from the people who sensed it and felt nervous and afraid, the entire world had seemed completely unaffected.

But very soon, he realized that this time the Sun's extinction had caused many things to go wrong—communications between city-states had been cut off, and the White Oak had witnessed that strange "boundary" out at sea.

And now, after the Sun lit up again, he discovered that the eerie impact of this event went far beyond those things—the entire Vanished had "teleported" over two-thirds of its route and appeared directly near Lightwind Harbor, while Tyrian reported that the other city-states had no idea the Sun had ever gone out at all…

It was as if, in the brief switch between the Sun's "extinction" and "rekindling", the whole world had briefly taken on a bizarre "form", sprouting rifts and dissonances everywhere. And the Vanished, this "ghost ship" that sailed at the edge of the Mortal Realm, had crossed that torn "chasm" for a short, lucid moment.

A terrifying idea burst into Duncan's mind before he could suppress it—

What was the Sun's true role?

Was it only there to provide light and heat, and to suppress the world's "supernatural corruption"? What was it actually suppressing—the supernatural corruption in this world… or the world itself?

"…Captain," Goathead's voice suddenly came from beside him, breaking Duncan's thoughts. "What do we do next? If the Vanished really is already

near Lightwind Harbor… should we contact Miss Lucretia?”

“…First we confirm our surroundings. Don’t approach the city-state rashly,” Duncan thought for a moment. He could not help remembering his earlier experiences in Pland and Frostholm, and he shook his head on instinct. “Have the Vanished hide in the Shadows and the fog. We’ll contact Lucretia when the time is right.”

Goathead’s head immediately drooped. “Yes, Captain.”

Duncan grunted in acknowledgement, then walked to the Oval Scrying Mirror in the corner of the room and tapped lightly on its surface.

Shadowy light rippled across the mirror. In the blink of an eye, Agatha appeared before him, dressed like a female adventurer.

“I really didn’t expect my first long voyage with you to be this incredible,” Agatha sighed. “Just as you said: by setting out with the Vanished, I would witness every unbelievable thing in this world. I really was too conservative in my imagination before we left.”

“Too much excitement for you?”

“It’s not so bad. Luckily I no longer have a heart that starts pounding at the slightest scare,” Agatha smiled faintly. “Next, you want me to watch for changes in the Spirit Realm, right?”

“The Spirit Realm, and those ‘reflections’ moving between the Spirit Realm and the Mortal Realm. If you can, keep an eye on what’s happening below the surface of the sea as well,” Duncan said bluntly. “I can’t shake the feeling that even though the Sun has lit up again, the aftereffects of this event are far from over. A little extra caution won’t hurt.”

“Understood,” Agatha put away her smile and nodded solemnly, then quickly added, “Ah, according to the ship’s rules, I should say it like this—yes, Captain!”

The figure in the mirror slowly faded.

Duncan's expression remained grave as he stood before the mirror in quiet thought.

…

Colorful paper scraps whirled over the streets, spiraled past the uneven rooftops and the gaps between buildings, and finally flew into a structure near the city-state's university—into the research room of the elven Grand Scholar Taran Ael.

Lucretia's form gathered out of the swirling paper.

A second later, the "Sea Witch" frowned in puzzlement.

She did not see the elven Grand Scholar anywhere in the room.

"…Don't tell me he's still stuck on the roof," Lucretia muttered, glancing at the nearby window that still stood open.

She was just about to fly up to the roof to check whether the elven Grand Scholar was stranded up there when hurried footsteps suddenly sounded from the corridor outside, breaking her movement.

Listening to the noise in the hallway, Lucretia casually flicked a hand toward the door.

With a bang, the door flew open. A stream of Shadows shot out along the line of her pointing finger into the corridor. Screams and the thud of someone falling followed. Moments later, an apprentice who was flailing and desperately trying to get back on his feet was "invited" into the room.

The apprentice came in lying down. It looked as if he were gliding ten centimeters above the floor into the room. Only when he finally stopped did the things "carrying" him swarm out from under his body—countless toy soldiers scrambled out from beneath the apprentice, quickly formed up in

ranks on the floor, then marched in step to the beat of drums and horns and darted back into the Shadows at Lucretia's side.

The apprentice who had been "invited" in stared in terror at the toy soldiers running across the floor. Only then did his gaze move to the master of those soldiers and Shadows. He lifted his head and saw Lucretia standing by the window, and at last realized who this faintly familiar lady was.

"Witch… ah, Lady Lucretia!" The apprentice scrambled upright and hurried to greet this big shot wreathed in legends and reputation. "Goo… good afternoon…"

As he spoke, he suddenly twitched. A tiny toy soldier crawled out of his pocket, fell to the floor, and smashed apart into several pieces. But in the next instant, the toy soldier reassembled, flipped to its feet, and sprinted back to its mistress, diving into the Shadows.

Lucretia ignored both the young apprentice's panicked awkwardness and the toy soldier that had fallen behind. She went straight to the point: "I'm here for your teacher. Where did he go?"

"I was just on my way to find him too," the apprentice swallowed hard and quickly answered this "witch" who was rumored to be cold and withdrawn, skilled in curses, and as fickle as the sea itself. "Someone saw him go to the Tower of Flowing Clouds when the Sun went out. He went… from the university roof…"

Lucretia raised an eyebrow. "From the university roof?"

"Y-yes, someone saw him. He seemed to be in a big hurry… and he still hasn't come back. I'm worried something happened to him…"

"Something would have to happen. With a hundred years of shoulder and neck problems, he's still scrambling over rooftops at the university— even as an elf, he shouldn't be trying extreme sports like that," Lucretia said

offhandedly, then waved at the young apprentice. “I’ll go check on him. By the way, what’s your name?”

The apprentice snapped to attention. “Jo… Joshua Dino.”

“Good. I’ll tell your teacher to dock three points from your conduct assessment.”

Joshua froze. “Why?”

Lucretia’s figure had already burst apart into a cloud of colorful paper, spiraling out through the window. Only one vague sentence drifted back to the young apprentice’s ears—

“…No running in the research building.”

Chapter 517: Slumber

The whirling paper scraps spun over the academy's roofs, followed the outer wall of the "high tower" all the way up, and reached the observation deck at the very top. There, at the edge of the platform, they gathered again into Lucretia's form.

The wide observation platform was very quiet. There was no sign of anyone.

Lucretia frowned and carefully examined the situation at the top of the tower.

The instruments for recording astronomical data were still running automatically. The massive lens array, held up by a forest of complicated mechanical arms, pointed its focus toward the sky. Three sets of lenses with filtering structures had been removed for the moment. From the looks of it, that part had been adjusted by hand.

The platform was empty—its original staff had probably evacuated in a hurry when the Sun went out. But the operating state of the lens array showed that someone had indeed come up here during the Sun's extinction and used this equipment to observe the Sun.

"…It was not a wise idea to observe the Sun under those conditions," Lucretia could not help murmuring.

She began to search near the lens array for any sign of Master Taran Ael. Just then, a pencil lying on the floor entered her field of view.

She ran over at once and finally found the elven scholar buried among a cluster of steaming pneumatic tube lines—Taran Ael lay quietly on the ground, eyes closed, as if he were in a deep coma.

Lucretia immediately knelt to check the elven scholar's condition. She found that his breathing was still steady and there was no sign his life was in danger. He had simply lost consciousness for some unknown reason. Then she waved a hand in the air—a crowd of toy soldiers rushed out from the Shadows at her feet, formed neat ranks, and charged toward the unconscious Grand Scholar.

The toy soldiers surrounded Taran Ael in an instant. They scrambled up and down his body, inspecting him as if checking a battlefield, their movements accompanied by rapid exchanges and reports. As they moved, Lucretia's expression gradually changed.

There were no external wounds. It was not a physical attack. There were no traces of poison or any curse.

The Sea Witch bent down and lifted the Grand Scholar's eyelids, then slapped his face without the slightest politeness, trying to rouse Taran Ael. It had no effect.

"He just seems to have fallen into some unknown sleep… hm?"

Lucretia let out a puzzled hum as she muttered to herself. Two toy soldiers had just pried open one of Taran Ael's hands, which had been clamped tightly to his chest. A sheet of rough sketch paper, nearly torn by his grip, came into view.

"What is this…"

Curious, Lucretia picked up the paper and smoothed it out. She saw only a roughly drawn circular shape, filled with many complex, chaotic lines. She stared at it for a long time and still could not find any pattern in those

strokes. They only felt like crisscrossing branches, or some tightly packed structure.

Clearly, whoever had drawn these patterns had done so in a rush and under intense confusion. Many of the lines on the paper showed hesitant smears. That meant the artist had not been sure what he was seeing—or had been unable to accurately reproduce the “truth” he had witnessed.

Lucretia stared at the sketch with a grave expression, then narrowed her eyes and looked up at the Sun that had already lit the sky again. She lowered her gaze to the fallen pencil, then to the pneumatic tube lines by Taran Ael’s side that led back toward the academy. In short order, she pieced together what had happened to the elven scholar.

When the Sun went out, the Grand Scholar had rushed up to the tower. He had wanted to use these “conditions”—something no number of filters or lenses could normally achieve—to observe the surface details of Vision 001. He had managed to draw a rough sketch and had then tried to send it to the academy at once through the “express dispatch” system. But at that very moment, some mysterious force had “struck” him, plunging him into instant slumber. He must have retained a few final shreds of awareness in the instant he fell—the way he clutched the sketch to his chest proved that…

But what had “struck” him? A saboteur who had infiltrated the tower? Or a mental corruption triggered by observing the Sun in its extinguished state?

Lucretia shook her head. It probably was not a saboteur.

The reason was simple. After Taran Ael had lost the ability to resist, he had suffered no further harm. The sketch he had guarded so tightly had not been stolen. None of the tower’s devices showed any signs of damage. No “intruder” would take such a huge risk to break into the tower only to make an elven scholar take a nap.

Just then, the grinding noise of the shaft lift cut off the Sea Witch's thoughts.

She turned toward the sound and saw the door of the shaft lift at the side of the platform slide open. Several scholars from the Truth Academy rushed out, their faces full of panic.

They froze when they noticed the Sea Witch standing on the tower top.

"Taran Ael observed the Sun while it was extinguished, and now he has fallen into an unexplained sleep," Lucretia said casually to the scholars, then raised the sketch in her hand. "I suggest you purify all the equipment here, in case some of the lenses that showed Vision 001's 'true form' were also tainted by corruption."

"This is what he drew before he lost consciousness. I'm taking it with me to confirm that it doesn't carry any corruption. If it's clean, I'll hand it back to you."

Without waiting for their response, she turned and walked toward the edge of the platform. Her body burst into colorful scraps of paper once more and rode the wind into the distance.

The scholars who had rushed here in a hurry after hearing the students' report only came back to themselves now. Watching the fading trail of paper, one of them could not help murmuring: "That witch really is…"

"Free to come and go. She's always been like that," another waved a hand and strode over to where Taran Ael still lay. "Let's get Master to a safe place first."

"She took the notes Master Taran Ael left behind… there won't be any problem, will there?" a younger human scholar asked worriedly. He clearly did not feel entirely at ease about the Sea Witch.

“Relax. Lady Lucretia may be eccentric and do as she pleases, but she has worked with the Truth Academy and the Explorer Association many times. She’s… a friend,” a middle-aged scholar said as he spoke, bending over to lift Taran Ael’s arm. “She’s the best border scholar and anti-corruption expert in the world. She has helped the academy handle many dangerous things. She will keep her promi—good grief, why is he so heavy?”

“You eat junk food every day, stay up all night, and never exercise. You’re just as heavy.”

“But I heard elves have a different constitution from other races. You have long lifespans and powerful metabolisms. Before you reach old age, it’s hard for you to put on fat, and you rarely get sick…”

“His talent did its best. It just couldn’t hold out…”

…

In the city-state of Pland, in a medical facility run by the council.

Heidi stood in the corridor, looking through the glass at the patient lying quietly in the ward. Then she turned to the council clerk who had brought her here and asked: “What’s the patient’s condition?”

“Deep sleep. We can’t wake her. There are no signs of external injury or poisoning,” the staff member in a dark blue uniform answered at once. “The patient had no prior chronic illnesses and has never been exposed to any potion or heretical faith that could cause this kind of sleep.”

“You’ve investigated pretty thoroughly,” Heidi said without thinking, then shook her head. “But I still have to say this: I’m a psychiatrist, not an internal medicine doctor. What I’m good at is dealing with problems of the mind and spirit, not sleep disorders. Someone who won’t wake up can’t exactly undergo counseling—you really should be calling a proper doctor, shouldn’t you?”

“We did, Heidi. The doctors concluded that the patient’s sleep has nothing to do with any physical illness,” the staffer said with a shake of his head. “After a full round of tests, we began to suspect…”

“…I understand,” Heidi cut him off gently. “You suspect it’s related to mental corruption or a mind-level Anomaly, right? But you just said the patient hasn’t been in contact with any sources of corruption.”

“That’s only the result of our preliminary investigation. There are many ways for mental corruption to spread. It doesn’t always require someone to actively touch something. They might simply ‘learn’ a certain piece of knowledge by chance, or maybe…”

He trailed off. Then he raised a hand and pointed upward, his face turning serious.

“Maybe it’s connected to the Sun’s extinction earlier. Right now we have no evidence that those twelve hours when the Sun went out can affect an ordinary person—but the patient in front of you might be the first ‘proof’.”

“I see. Then this is my field,” Heidi drew a slow breath, picked up her medical case, and walked toward the ward door. Just before she went in, she turned back to remind him: “Don’t let anyone approach during the treatment. If any supernatural phenomena occur near this room, inform the priests and guardians here at once.”

“Understood, Heidi.”

Heidi nodded and pushed the door open.

The smell of disinfectant mixed with holy oil and incense filled her nose. In the bright, spacious ward, a single patient lay on the only bed.

Heidi silently recited the name of the God of Wisdom, Rahm, in her heart, then checked the charm amulet of colored stones on her wrist and carefully approached the bed.

A young maiden lay there with her eyes closed, as if trapped deep in an uneasy dream, so still it looked as though… the link between her body and soul had already been severed.

Before opening her case, Heidi first did what she always did—she studied the patient's face.

"An elf?"

Chapter 518: Treatment, ritual, and Gunpowder

When Heidi saw that her new patient was an Elf, she felt a bit surprised.

She rarely treated Elf patients. It was not just psychiatrists like her. Most other kinds of doctors also usually did not deal with Elves.

The Elven race had a body that made other races envious. Besides their long lifespans, they almost never became sick. Most of the time they were unbelievably healthy and could live well even in harsh conditions. Along with their strong bodies, their minds were usually very tough. Maybe to adapt to their long lives, Elves had very stable mental states. They were not as strong as the Senkin, who were known as having “stone hearts”, but they were much stronger than Humans.

Because of these gifts, many great pioneers and adventurers in history had Elven blood. They were good at, and dared to, move through the “border” seas. They could survive the dangerous fog and illusions there and still return home. Now, among the many city-states on the Boundless Sea, almost two-thirds of the “border” city-states near the eternal Veil had been founded by Elven pioneers. The most famous of them was Lightwind Harbor, the city of adventure.

In all Heidi’s years working as a psychiatrist, she had almost never heard of an Elf with psychological problems.

Of course, mortals always had weaknesses. Even Elves with such great “talent” were no exception. Compared with Humans, they grew slowly and

learned more slowly. Their minds were so tough that holy powers could hardly bless them at all. Only the power of the God of Wisdom worked on them in a normal way. The blessings of the other orthodox Three Gods had very little effect on Elves. Strangely, the Senkin, who also had very stable minds, did not have this problem and were much better off in this regard.

Many people had guessed what caused Elves to be “hard to bless”. After all, the mental toughness of the Senkin was also high, yet they did not have this “weakened blessing” flaw. Among the many guesses, one theory spread quite widely: the old and stubborn heretic worship in traditional Elven culture had made them hated by the Gods. Only the God of Wisdom, as the Protector of all rational beings, was willing to show them mercy.

In history, before the new Age of City-States began, during the Dark Age and the old Age of City-States, this “god-abandoned” nature of the Elves, plus the natural prejudice between different races, had even caused many bloody conflicts. But in the end, Elves used the steam rifles and high explosives they invented to reach mutual “understanding” with the other races of the mortal world.

After that, this long-lived and broad-minded race graciously accepted the signals of reconciliation from Humans and Senkin. They had lived in peace with the descendants of those short-lived races up to this very day.

Heidi walked up to the bed. She tested the Elven maiden’s breath and checked her heartbeat. Then she opened her medical case and calmly laid out different potions and devices on the small table beside the bed.

Those days of conflict and darkness had already become history. Short-lived Humans and Senkin could only learn their ancestors’ stories from books. Even the long-lived Elves now treated those distant days as small, unimportant events that had happened when they were young, or during their parents’ time.

Today, the Elves' "god-abandoned" nature still existed. Many of their old families, while accepting the teachings of the God of Wisdom Rahm, still kept many mysterious and traditional heretic beliefs. But this did not stop them from being a very important part of the civilized world.

In fact, because of their great skill in mathematics and machinery, and because their faith in the God of Wisdom Rahm grew deeper and deeper, the Elves held a key position in this age of steam and electricity. If not for their clear disadvantage in numbers, their influence on the Boundless Sea might already have surpassed that of Humans.

In any case, in this age, no one kept nagging about the Elves' folk heretic beliefs that had survived until now. No one talked about their bodies that could not be blessed by the Three Gods.

Heidi lit a delicate censer. A calming scent slowly spread beside the bed. In the drifting aroma, the Elf maiden on the bed seemed to relax her brow a little.

Heidi bent down and lifted the maiden's eyelid. She held a faintly glowing purple crystal before the maiden's eyes and slowly moved it left and right.

"You are still trapped in a dream," Heidi said softly. "Your tense and uneasy feelings have woven themselves into a cage that protects you. But now you need help, so you will leave a 'key' to someone you choose to trust. This person you trust deeply will appear in your dream. They will help you fight the things that frighten you, or help you find the way out of the dream…"

Heidi slowly swung the crystal. With the incense smoke rising beside them, she spoke in a low, gentle tone that sounded almost magical next to the maiden's ear.

As a psychiatrist, she had many ways to help her patients. In normal treatment, she was very good at using questionnaires and psychological

hints to check a patient's mental state and give targeted guidance. But when things were not so normal… she also had many other methods that worked very well.

These very effective methods included blackjacks, golden needles, and gunpowder. They also included Focusing Incense, potions, and ritual crystals.

After all, psychiatry was a line of work full of danger. On normal days she did not only deal with sleepless, nervous students and office workers. She also dealt with the filth that jumped out from her patients' dreams and imaginations.

"Now you are starting to feel a little calmer," Heidi continued. "Because the person who will help you will soon appear in your dream…"

As Heidi kept speaking gently, she noticed a faint silver light appear deep inside the Elf maiden's pupils. This was the sign that the blessing of the God of Wisdom Rahm was starting to work. Luckily, even though this race had a "god-abandoned" nature, they could still accept Rahm's blessing in a normal way. This eased Heidi's heart a lot, as a believer of the God of Wisdom.

"You have left a door for them," Heidi said. "That door is very close to you. You have already given the key to the person who will help you. Now you are hiding in a safe place, quietly waiting for that door to open…

"You feel safe, because you know that the one who will walk through that door is the person you trust the most…"

Heidi spoke softly. As her last words fell, the Elf maiden's breathing clearly became long and calm.

This was only temporary.

But Heidi had already prepared for the next step of "treatment".

She quickly left the Elf maiden’s side. Holding the purple crystal pendant she had just used for hypnosis, she lay down on an empty bed beside it.

She gripped the purple crystal that she had received from her father and quietly recited a prayer to the God of Wisdom Rahm, then slowly closed her eyes.

After a while, she opened her eyes and sat up with a puzzled look.

She had not fallen into any dream at all. Had the hypnosis failed?

Heidi got up from the bed. She carefully checked the surroundings, then walked back to the bed where the Elf maiden lay.

Her patient still lay there quietly, with no sign of waking.

After checking again and again for quite a long time, and trying hypnosis twice more to no effect, Heidi found that she simply could not connect to this Elf maiden’s dream.

A wave of frustration rose in her chest.

She stood by the bed and stayed frustrated for a while, quietly thinking about other treatment plans. After who knew how long, she sighed, rolled her sore shoulders and neck, and stood up to walk toward the ward door.

But before she touched the door, footsteps sounded from outside. Then she heard a key turning. As the handle turned, the council clerk in a dark blue uniform opened the ward door.

“Miss Heidi, how is the situation?”

The staff member seemed to have been waiting in the “safe zone” outside for a long time. Now he asked about the progress of the treatment, looking rather nervous.

“There is still no effect,” Heidi said, shaking her head with regret. “The usual hypnosis methods failed. I may need to prepare some stronger rituals or potions.” As she spoke, she lifted the purple crystal pendant and hung it back on her chest. Then she picked up her heavy case. “I need to go back and think carefully about the next treatment plan.”

“…All right, I am sure you did your best this time,” the staff member sighed with understanding. “Other psychiatrists have tried before, but none of them could break into this patient’s dream. Because the situation is too strange, the priest sent by the Cathedral is very worried that this is some kind of bizarre mental corruption caused by the Sun going out. They take it very seriously… But there is nothing we can do. If even an expert like you finds it so tricky, then we really cannot rush it.”

Heidi nodded lightly.

Vaguely, she felt the purple crystal pendant on her chest give off a faint warmth.

“Do you need us to arrange a vehicle to send you back?” the staff member asked politely.

“No need. My car is parked outside,” Heidi said, shaking her head.

“All right, then I will not see you off. Just go back the way you came. I will go and check on the patient again.”

Heidi gave a small sound in reply and showed the staff member a friendly smile. Then she turned and walked toward the long, deep corridor outside.

Behind her, the staff member in the blue uniform also turned and walked toward the Elf maiden who was still asleep.

Footsteps sounded behind her, now about five meters away.

Heidi silently lifted her case. Her other hand reached for the hidden compartment at the bottom of the case. Then she turned around with a blank face and pulled the trigger.

“Bang!”

The bullet pierced the back of the figure in the blue uniform and burst into a hazy cloud of blood.

Chapter 519: Field of Expertise

With a loud bang, the figure in the blue uniform fell to the floor. Blood slowly spread out from under his body. His heart had been torn apart. The body twitched hard a few times, then slowly stopped moving.

The scene looked like a clear, simple murder. Even the twitching of the body after it fell seemed to keep stressing the “murder” in front of her, and kept telling Heidi that she had just killed an ordinary person.

But Heidi only watched it all with no expression. While the corpse twitched on the ground, she tilted her head and listened for the slightest sound around her.

Under normal circumstances, that loud gunshot would be enough to echo through the whole floor. The security guards and the Church guardians stationed in this facility should have been alarmed by now. But in fact, after the gunshot, the corridor stayed completely silent. No one appeared at all, as if… this whole facility had already been empty for a long time.

The purple crystal pendant hanging at her chest still gave off a faint warmth. Some blessing that did not belong to the Four Gods, but was still very effective, kept Heidi’s thoughts clear.

This pendant was not the first one. The pendant that Father had brought back from that antique shop the first time had already run dry and shattered during the earlier Black Sun incident. The one she wore now was the “gift” that the boss of that antique shop had given Father the second time.

It turned out that this pendant still had the same astonishing power as the first one.

After a brief silence, Heidi let out a soft breath. One hand held the revolver she had just taken from the hidden compartment in her case. With her other hand she set the case on the floor and took out a long golden spike from inside it. It was one of her medical tools. Her eyes never left the body on the ground as she said: “Your acting is good, but can you stop now?”

The “corpse” had long since stopped twitching. After Heidi finished speaking, it finally moved. Then, as if nothing had happened, the man got up from the floor. With the horrible bullet wound still in his chest, he turned to look at the psychiatrist who had just “killed” him and said: “I am very curious. When did you notice?”

Heidi held the gun in one hand and gripped the golden spike tightly in the other. She looked at the Dream Invader in front of her with caution and calmness and said: “There is only one bed in this ward. So when I lay down on the ‘empty bed’ beside it, this fight had already begun.”

“How interesting… Very few people can still notice such a mistake after they have already fallen into Dreamwalking, at least not this fast,” the intruder said at an easy pace. In the air beside him, a dark, hazy shadow or smoke began to appear. It slowly gathered into a solid form. “That includes those so-called ‘psychiatrists’ who have had professional training.”

Heidi frowned at the cloud of smoky shadow beside him. At last she made out its shape, and her eyes changed at once: “Smokewisp Jellyfish… an Annihilator?”

The moment she recognized the shadow, its vague outline became clear. A “jellyfish” made of smoke and dust floated in midair. A pitch-black chain linked it to the intruder’s skull. This dangerous demon creature pulsed and

writhed. Countless tentacle-like structures spread over its surface, and at some point they had already reached very close around Heidi!

A huge sense of danger exploded in her heart. Heidi felt the corruption and destruction taking place in her own mental world. The enemy's attack was secret and sly, and it had already begun. If not for her sudden flash of intuition that let her recognize the shape of the Smokewisp Jellyfish in this dream, by the time she reacted she would already have fallen to the Smokewisp Jellyfish's Mental Parasitism!

In the next instant, she did not hesitate at all. She raised the sharp golden spike in her hand and drove it hard into her own temple.

The next second, a thunder-like boom exploded inside her head. Everything in her sight began to shake and tremble. The ward that had looked normal a moment ago twisted and warped at once. The walls melted like wax, revealing a disgusting inside like withered flesh. The floor turned into dry, scorched earth, full of ugly cracks and filthy, writhing things. The Smokewisp Jellyfish, with its many stretching tendrils, seemed to be badly wounded. It let out a shrill scream, and all its tentacles shrank wildly.

Right after that, the Annihilator disguised as a council clerk, and the Smokewisp Jellyfish in a symbiotic pact with him, both vanished from Heidi's sight like mist.

But Heidi did not relax at all. She still gripped her gun and the golden spike, watching for any wrongness in the twisted surroundings while quickly checking her own mental state. She knew that the Dream Invader had not been defeated and had not even left.

This dream showed no sign of breaking apart or fading.

The knowledge she had studied while taking advanced courses at Truth Academy slowly rose up in her mind.

Smokewisp Jellyfish… a branch of Abyssal demons. They had formless bodies like smoke and many strange and dangerous supernatural powers. They were especially good at attacking a victim's mind and senses. Summoners who formed a symbiotic pact with such demons could use mind-damaging spells, or draw the energy of Abyssal demons and fire it as corrosive projectiles.

Compared with most Abyssal demons, the body of a Smokewisp Jellyfish was not very tough. But their eerie supernatural powers made them one of the most dangerous Abyssal demons. In many cases, you would have no chance to strike their fragile bodies before the wounds on your mind took away your chance to resist. The cunning cultists who formed symbiotic pacts with Smokewisp Jellyfish would even work on purpose to amplify these "traits" of the Abyssal demons, making them even harder to handle.

The heat from the purple crystal pendant on her chest grew stronger. Heidi could feel that some malicious "components" in this dream were still trying to Corrupt and damage her mind. But the power released by the pendant protected her, kept breaking down those intrusions, and held her mind clear.

In this stalemate between corruption and protection, a new sense of danger suddenly rose in her heart.

Heidi followed this feeling at once and raised her gun. But the figure that appeared out of the air at the very moment she aimed made her stop.

Morris appeared there, staring at her in shock.

"Heidi?" that familiar figure said, confused and worried. "What is going on… have you been trapped in a nightmare?!"

"Yes," Heidi said, nodding as she pulled the trigger without a second thought. She fired while she spoke: "I do not know what is going on either. An Annihilator interfered with my hypnosis treatment. But as far as I

remember, even a Smokewisp Jellyfish does not have the power to control the realm of dreams."

The muzzle flash lit up. The gun roared. Father's figure took the bullet. An expression of disbelief froze on his face. He swayed twice, then fell backward.

In the next second, another figure appeared where Father had fallen. It was an old woman with a gentle face and a look of concern. Mother.

"Heidi, what are you doing? Why are you—"

"I am treating my patient," Heidi said casually as she pulled the trigger.

Mother's figure fell as well. But right after that, a very tall figure appeared in her sight. This time, the figure had only formed a rough outline of Vanna before Heidi fired first.

Another phantom fell.

"You really are not putting your heart into this, Mr. Intruder," Heidi said, shaking her head. "How could such simple tricks work? Especially with Vanna. If it were really her, when I fired she would just pinch the bullet between her fingers, roll it into a ball, and throw it back…"

Those constantly appearing figures finally stopped.

But an angry, low voice suddenly came from some unknown place: "Why are you not affected?"

"I already know this is a twisted dream, so of course I will not believe the phantoms you make," Heidi said calmly. "Of course, I do not think that is what surprises you. You are surprised that my mind has not wavered at all. After all, even if they know it is all an illusion, if an ordinary person keeps seeing familiar faces die in front of them by their own hand, that process will build up huge mental pressure and finally break through their line of

reason. That has nothing to do with being ‘awake’ or not… But sadly for you, I have had some training.”

As she spoke, this Miss Psychiatrist slowly raised the muzzle of the gun and pressed it against her own temple.

“Do you know how much weight a combined master’s and doctorate with a full scholarship from Truth Academy carries, Mr. Intruder—”

“Bang!”

The trigger snapped. The gun roared. Heidi shot through her own head without the slightest hesitation. As her body swayed, another Heidi stepped out from beside her in an instant!

Bang, bang, bang. Gunshots rang out again and again. The revolver, which should only have held six bullets, kept firing as if it had endless rounds. Heidi kept pulling the trigger against her own temple. One Personality Split after another walked out from beside her. Each one held a golden spike as they moved toward every corner of the ward that had twisted into a nightmare, toward the door, and toward the corridor outside.

“You should not have provoked me in my own field of expertise, Mr. Intruder,” Heidi said. She slowly raised her head and pulled the trigger at her own skull one last time. “And you really should not have made trouble while I was treating a patient. I really, really, really hate working overtime!”

Dozens of Personality Splits quickly spread out, scattering through every part of this already warped “medical facility”. They began to search this invaded dream for any suspicious clues, and to seek out the “cognitive voids” at the edges of the dream that might be Invasion Paths or hiding places.

However, as the Personality Splits moved, Heidi suddenly frowned.

“…Gone?” she murmured.

Chapter 520

The Intruder’s mental presence vanished, but it was not because she had destroyed it. Somehow, it had broken away from this “building” shaped by a twisted dream.

Heidi frowned as she sensed the steady flow of information coming back from the Personality Splits she had sent out. At the same time, she let her gaze sweep across the “ward” in front of her.

As the Intruder’s mental presence faded, the ward quickly returned to how it had first looked. The horrible deformed scenes caused by the corruption slowly peeled away. Walls that had looked like withered flesh turned back into the clean white walls of a medical facility. The cracked, rot-blackened ground became an ordinary floor again. Outside the ward, the gloomy, frightening air that had filled the whole facility also began to scatter.

But Heidi did not relax her brow at all. Instead, she grew even more alert at these strange changes.

Because this was not normal. A dream twisted by corruption was a closed structure. Inside it, the Intruder’s mind was the attacking side of the dream, but also a part of the dream itself. If that mind tried to force its way out of the dream, it would definitely cause a huge disturbance. A powerful dream Expert could press that disturbance down until it was very small, of course. But that Intruder… was not that strong.

Heidi knew her own ability. She had been an outstanding student at the Truth Academy and had received careful instruction from Father since she

was a child. She had always been confident in the field of dreams. She did not believe that this Intruder could leave this twisted nightmare without her noticing at all. The other party must have found some way to hide, or slipped into some Cognitive Void.

She hesitated for a moment, then slowly walked toward the bed in the middle of the room.

The unfamiliar elven maiden still lay quietly on the bed, her brows tightly knit, showing no sign of waking.

In theory, this maiden was the core of the dream. Her being trapped had caused this twisted “medical facility” to appear in her dream. Under normal conditions, she should have woken up by now.

Because the Intruder’s power had already left. Whether that cultist had only hidden himself or had really run away, the corruption he had left here had clearly faded. Once the corruption faded, the one trapped in the dream should wake up at once. That was what made sense.

Because in most cases, a person could do countless strange things in their own dream, but there was one thing they could not do: keep sleeping inside the dream.

Even in dreams nested inside dreams, at the deepest layer the person’s mind was always active.

Heidi stepped forward to check the elven maiden’s condition. Then she hesitated, helped the girl sit up, and then pushed her hard back onto the bed.

It had no effect. Her patient still slept on.

“The Falling Reflex isn’t working…” Heidi muttered to herself, her serious face full of thought. “So this still isn’t her final layer of dream? Just a ‘middle layer’ of a dream within a dream? That doesn’t make sense… Even in a middle layer, the Falling Reflex should be able to wake her…”

She kept muttering, then suddenly stopped, as if something had just come to her mind. She turned around and ran out of the ward.

Her hurried footsteps echoed through the medical facility. Heidi ran quickly down the deep, long corridor. Along the way, she saw the Personality Splits she had released earlier. Those other “Heidis” holding golden awls were still roaming all over the facility, searching the place. Some checked the corridors, some checked the stairwells, and some checked those half-open doors of eerie, empty rooms. They all looked very busy.

Heidi ran past these Personality Splits. Each time she passed one, that split turned and rushed back into her body. The splits scattered in other parts of the facility also received the order. They appeared one after another from nearby junctions and each returned to the main body.

The medical facility no longer kept the layout she knew. The dream’s misaligned projection had caused a mess of corridors, dead ends, and side passages to appear inside the building. Some stairways were even flipped and twisted, linking rooms and halls that made no sense at all in real space, like something out of an absurd abstract painting. The sight was deeply strange.

Yet such a chaotic space was nothing special for Heidi, who often dealt with dreams. She easily picked out the right paths, avoided the dead ends that would lead into endless loops, and at last reached the end of the way—

A great door stood quietly before her eyes, and the word “Exit” was written upon it.

Heidi stopped. The last Personality Split ran up from behind and quickly merged back into her body. She took a light breath and walked slowly toward the door.

That was the exit of the “medical facility” and, in theory, also the “edge” of this twisted dream.

She placed her hand on the door handle and slowly calmed her heartbeat.

The edge of a dream was dangerous. It marked the Dreamer’s limit of understanding. As a Visitor, stepping over the Dreamer’s limit at random meant letting her own mind fall into a huge “undefined” region. In this chaotic zone, no longer under the Dreamer’s control and ruled by the subconscious, unwelcome intruders could meet all kinds of dangers. They might even face those terrifying things that wandered along the border of Mortal reason and lay hidden in the Spirit Realm.

Heidi hesitated. Going any farther would not fit any medical guideline.

The purple crystal pendant hanging at her chest no longer felt hot. This “shoddy product”, which was in truth only a piece of cheap glass, had gone completely cold.

Feeling the chill from the pendant, Heidi made up her mind.

This strange little pendant had not gone wrong even once so far. She decided to trust its reaction.

“If this were on a professional exam, they would knock at least fifteen points off for this step…”

Miss Psychiatrist muttered this under her breath and pushed the door open with force.

The vast darkness and chaotic Shadows she had expected did not appear. She saw no terrifying abyssal rifts and no Spirit Realm monsters.

Heidi stood at the edge of the dream, staring, dumbfounded, at the scene before her.

A lush… forest spread out before her eyes.

Everywhere she looked, there were towering trees she had never seen before. Their thick, leafy crowns overlapped and crossed high above, blocking out the sky and sun. Countless flowers, grasses, and bushes covered the ground. Between them she could see clumps of trees of all sizes and lively creeper vines. Now and then, the cries of unknown birds echoed between the giant trunks. The sound felt new and yet… strange.

sunlight poured over the dense woods, and the life it brought was something Heidi, who had lived in a city-state since childhood, had never seen before.

She could not even understand what she was seeing.

She could not imagine why so many huge trees would grow together like this. Why such precious land would be covered with strange plants instead of houses and roads. Why she could not hear the sound of the sea in her ears and could only smell plants and soil through her nose.

She fell into confusion, a confusion of both senses and mind. Even as a top student in the Truth Academy with a full scholarship and a combined master’s and doctorate track, she grew dazed for a moment. She almost forgot where she was and what she was supposed to do.

Luckily, years of professional training and her strong mental self-control pulled her back. After only a few seconds of blankness, she snapped herself awake, took a deep breath, and forced herself back into a calm, thinking state.

Then she looked back in the direction she had come from.

The “medical facility” stood right behind her, wrapped in huge trees and countless interwoven vines. Unknown plants crawled over its walls. The man-made building stood in the forest as something sudden and out of place.

But Heidi quickly drew a few conclusions from this jarring sight—

“The dream’s range really should be limited to the inside of this medical facility. This strange place outside the door is not part of the normal dream structure… Some kind of mutated ‘edge-awareness zone’?

“I can’t see any element tied to the city-state of Pland. It’s all plants I don’t know… Is this a scene inside this elf’s subconscious? But even elven city-states like Lightwind Harbor or Morka don’t have vegetation on this scale…

“Or… is this outside space the real ‘final layer of dream’? But the scale is far too big, and there are so many details… Her brain should have burned out long ago if that were the case…”

Heidi muttered to herself in confusion. Then she felt around beside her and pulled out a brightly colored ball of yarn.

She hooked the end of the yarn around her finger and threw the ball hard into the distance.

The bright ball of yarn rolled across the ground, bouncing and spreading over damp stones, soil, and vines.

Heidi watched every moment of the yarn’s rolling path, making sure none of the lines that landed on the ground turned blurry or strange.

If they did, it would prove that this place, which looked so “rich in detail”, hid a Cognitive Void. She would have to avoid those gaps with care, so that she did not fall into a nightmare.

The ball of yarn rolled smoothly into the distance without any abnormal sign.

Heidi let out a small breath of relief. Following roughly along the path the yarn had taken, she finally took her first step into this plant-covered “strange place”.

She had already put away her revolver for the moment and only gripped the protective golden awl tightly in her left hand.

In this unclear “border zone”, it was best not to use anything that caused too much noise. The lush plants here looked pleasant enough, but in the silence of the surroundings, who knew what might be hiding?

She had to be careful not to awaken those “beings” that slept at the edge of Mortal awareness.

As she moved forward with care, a question slowly rose in Heidi’s heart:

Had that cultist escaped the dream in a similar way? Had he not “woken up”, but instead run straight out here, to this strange place beyond the dream?

Could there be some trap waiting ahead?

All kinds of ideas spun through Heidi’s mind, but suddenly her heart gave a jolt.

In the next second, she snapped her head up and looked in the direction her intuition pointed.

Between several unknown trees, on a small open patch in the woods, a figure stood quietly with its back to her.

It was a stranger in a light-colored coat of southern style. The figure had messy blond hair and a slightly hunched back. Even though the stranger faced away from her, the two long, sharp ears poking out from the hair were the first thing to catch Heidi’s eye.

An elf?

Chapter 521

Outside the edge of the elven maiden’s dream, another elf had appeared.

Heidi’s heart tensed at once.

Under normal conditions, no other “mind entity” should appear outside the edge of a dream. That region was, in essence, a chaotic projection formed where the Dreamer’s subconscious border met the Mortal Realm. There, the Dreamer’s own reason no longer worked. The broken, chaotic subconscious was disturbed by the world’s deep layers and gave rise to all kinds of strange or dangerously eerie Shadows. Those Shadows were so dangerous that a human’s mental barrier had to work at full strength on that level just to stop the border’s information from seeping inward.

Heidi still clearly remembered what her teacher had said when she studied at the Truth Academy: every person was actually “blindfolded” in their own dreams. If they ever truly saw what the edge of their dreams looked like, everyone in this world would go mad.

So, as long as the mental barrier worked as it should, the Dreamer would never “perceive” the region beyond their dream’s edge and would never form any mind entity there.

Heidi tightened her grip on the golden awl again and silently recited Rahm’s name in her heart, so that the awl in her hand would carry the suggestive power to kill dream Intruders. She knew very well that the figure here could only be one of two things: a “doctor” like herself, or… another Intruder.

The figure with its back to her seemed not to notice Miss Psychiatrist drawing closer behind him. He still stood there in a daze, head slightly raised, as if watching the tree crowns that hid the sky with full attention.

Under those crowns, sunlight bathed the forest. If that figure standing there had not felt so out of place, it would have been a very pleasant view.

Heidi came up behind the mind entity. She suddenly raised her hand and pressed the golden awl against the back of his head. Yet, just as she was about to drive it in, she forced herself to stop.

Not an Intruder!

The golden awl, blessed by Rahm's divine blessing, was a surgical tool used to treat nerve disorders in the Mortal Realm. In the mental field, it served as a suggestive vessel with various supernatural powers. It could be used to destroy Shadows in the mind or to build temporary mental contact. Now, as the awl touched him, a clear and steady mind response flowed into Heidi's senses, along with the tight link between this mind entity and the surrounding environment. The well-trained Miss Psychiatrist grasped at once what this meant—

She had touched another Dreamer.

This was not the "outside region" of the elven maiden's dream. This was another elf's dream!

A wave of shock and confusion rose in an instant. Since she had graduated, Heidi had never met such a strange case in her field. Inside one patient's dream, she had found another Dreamer. Two dreams had merged into one, and she could not even sense a "border" between them!

A thought she could not hold back flashed through Heidi's mind—she already had a topic for her next journal paper. But if she really wrote this into a paper, even the most wild-minded psychology scholars at the Truth

Academy would probably sail day and night to Pland just to challenge her in person…

Her thoughts flashed by like lightning. Heidi quickly pulled back the golden awl and hid it behind her. Only then did the slightly hunched, blond figure in front of her finally react and slowly turn his head.

A face filled with tiredness and confusion came into Heidi's view.

At once, she thought of some of the frightening last-minute exam students she had seen back in the Academy.

They did not eat, did not sleep, did not rest—and still failed.

"Hello," the face said. It was so tired it looked as if he had barely slept in his whole life. His tone was slow, as if he were still half-asleep. "Are you also here to kill me in my dream?"

Heidi's confused thoughts cleared at once. She reacted instantly: "Also? Someone already attacked you in your dream?"

"A few," the middle-aged elf with messy blond hair nodded. He lifted his hand and pointed to the ground not far away. "Look, over there."

"A f-few?" Heidi was a little stunned. She followed the direction of his finger and saw only a few small blackened lumps on the open ground. "They are…"

"I don't know where they came from. I just asked them a few questions, and then they became like that," the middle-aged elf said slowly. He looked so drained it seemed he might fall asleep at any moment. Then he shook his head again. "They were all key points I had marked earlier…"

Heidi frowned slightly.

Something was wrong with this elf's mental state. He seemed to be mixing things up in the dream. In his haze, he had spoken of "marked key

points”… Was this coming from his role and work in the Mortal Realm? Was he a teacher? Or a scholar?

This elf knew he was in a dream and knew he had been attacked there, yet his understanding still showed clear confusion. Had it been damaged in one of the earlier attacks? Or had something “affected” him during his Dreamwalking?

“You still haven’t answered my question, lady,” the middle-aged elf’s voice came again while Heidi was thinking fast. “Are you also here to attack me?”

“No,” Heidi shook her head at once. His slow, calm questioning in such a strange and tense situation made her feel very uneasy, but she still chose to state her identity. “I am a psychiatrist.”

He frowned at this: “A psychiatrist?”

“Yes, a psychiatrist,” Heidi nodded at once. She calmly drew the golden awl that stood for her profession from behind her, then passed her hand over her forehead and eyes. “And also a believer of Rahm.”

“Oh, a professional,” the middle-aged elf slowly nodded and spoke in a dull way. “It seems my students sent you here, then. They finally noticed their teacher was trapped in a dream? I thought they would use this chance to take two days off…”

The elf in front of her seemed to have misunderstood something.

But Heidi had no wish to correct him. A “reason to intervene” that the Dreamer himself accepted was clearly a good thing. It would help her stay in this dream in a more stable way.

“My name is Heidi. I am glad I was able to find you,” Heidi said politely. “May I ask how you fell into this dream?”

“How I fell into this dream? I’m not very sure,” the middle-aged elf said, frowning. “But I still remember what I was doing before… I was on a tower, observing the Sun, the Sun… Right! The Sun! Miss Heidi, the Sun went out, and I was using that chance to study its surface structure. What is the situation outside now? When you came here, was the Sun still out?”

“The Sun has already lit up again,” Heidi answered, quickly taking in the clues he had given while she spoke. At the same time she tried to guess where this elf was in the Mortal Realm.

He had mentioned a “tower”, but Pland had no tower built just to observe the Sun. If this elf, who seemed to be a teacher or scholar, meant a kind of professional research when he said “observe”, then he must be in a tall tower with full equipment.

Where could that be? Morka? Asudi? Or Lightwind Harbor?

And to study the Sun’s surface while it was out… Such bold action already went beyond what a normal scholar would dare. Even her own Father would likely hesitate before doing something like that. What background did this elf have? What city-state would have such an elven scholar who neither valued his own life nor bothered to sleep?

Just as a few guesses began to form in her mind, the middle-aged elf spoke again.

His gaze passed over the golden awl in Heidi’s hand. He thought for a moment, as if he had only just remembered something.

“Miss Heidi,” he asked politely, “were you poking the back of my neck with that thing just now?”

Heidi: “…”

[How is he only just remembering to ask that now?!]

…

“Master Taran Ael is still not waking up?”

Lucretia frowned. She looked at the elven master lying quietly on the bed, eyes closed with no sign at all of waking. Her expression grew slightly stern.

Earlier, she had taken the “manuscript” Taran Ael had left and returned to the Radiant Star. But after a first check, she had found no clues at all, so she had come to Lightwind Harbor to ask about his condition. She had not expected that this elven Grand Scholar would still be trapped in deep sleep.

This city-state had many skilled doctors and outstanding scholars from the Truth Academy, yet none of them could wake Taran Ael from his coma?

“Y-yes, Lady Lucretia,” said a young man in the ward who had come to care for the Grand Scholar. He spoke with a slight stammer. Faced with the “sea witch” who carried so many strange tales, the young apprentice was clearly very nervous. “The doctors say Teacher is neither hurt nor poisoned. It looks more like he is trapped in a nightmare. This might be an ‘effect’ caused by the Sun going out…”

Lucretia frowned and let her gaze sweep over the other people in the room. Among the apprentices, she caught sight of a face that looked faintly familiar.

“Joshua, your Teacher should know protective skills in the field of spirit and psychology, right?”

“Yes, Lady Lucretia,” answered the young apprentice who had once been caught by the “sea witch” while running in the corridor. “Teacher often has to deal with strange objects found in the border regions, so he has trained in mind protection before…”

“So that means Taran Ael has the skills to stay clear-headed and protect himself in a nightmare. Under normal conditions he should be able to break free of the dream on his own—but the situation now has gone beyond his ability.”

“We have already gone to call a psychiatrist!” Joshua said in a rush. “They will be here soon!”

“An ordinary psychiatrist probably won’t be able to help much. This is no longer a simple nightmare,” Lucretia shook her head. “I am going to take him to the Radiant Star. My laboratory there should be useful.”

Chapter 522: Morris’s Hypothesis

In a certain laboratory deep inside the Radiant Star, Lucretia finished a rough examination of Taran Ael.

With the help of Truth Academy, moving this Grand Scholar onto the ship was not hard. But finding out what had happened to him was clearly not so simple. Even Lucretia, the “Sea Witch” who was well?traveled and famous in occult studies and the field of the curse, was seeing a case like this for the first time.

Taran Ael was clearly trapped deep inside some kind of dream. But his condition showed no reaction from the curse at all, and there was no sign of mental corruption.

Lucretia lit three candelabra in the corner of the lab and sprinkled her own herbal powder into the Censer in front of them. Then she went to Taran Ael’s side and set crystals, bone shards, and other items around him.

The clockwork doll Lunie, with a ceramic shell, and the stuffed rabbit doll Rabby were helping in the lab. When Lunie noticed the serious look on her Mistress’s face, Lunie could not hold back and asked: “Is it very bad? Is this elf in danger?”

“Situation unclear—that is worse than just bad,” Lucretia said seriously. “Taran Ael fell asleep after he tried to observe the Sun. If these two things are linked, it means this kind of sleep may not be a one?time case. While the Sun was out, how many people looked up? How closely did someone

have to ‘observe’ for this sleep to start? How many people did something as bold as this elf scholar?”

She slowly shook her head.

“Taran Ael acted very boldly, but on the vast Boundless Sea, there is more than one scholar with courage like his.”

“Do you need us to do anything else?” The stuffed rabbit doll Rabby hopped over, raised her head, and asked in a soft voice.

“Next, I will try to link into Taran Ael’s dream and help him open a path back to the Mortal Realm from the other side,” Lucretia said. “But this dream may be very complicated. I need you two to guard the candelabra in this room. If I am still not awake after three hours, you must snuff out all the candles from the tallest to the shortest. That will forcefully wake me up.”

“Yes,” Lunie lowered her head. “Three hours, snuff them out from tall to short. I remember.”

“Rabby can dream with Mistress!” The stuffed rabbit hopped over, hugged Lucretia’s leg, and said with some excitement: “Rabby is a rabbit that can dream!”

“One nightmare is enough,” Lucretia refused the stuffed rabbit doll without hesitation. “I don’t want a Grand Scholar like this dropping dead on my ship.”

“Fine, fine, Rabby knows~” The stuffed rabbit doll lowered her head and let out a sad sound. She muttered to herself as she walked to the corner of the room, then sat down on the floor with a soft “plop.”

Lucretia glanced at the doll once and did not answer. After she checked that all the ritual elements were ready, she sat in a high?backed chair facing Taran Ael and snapped her fingers.

The three quietly burning candelabra in the corner were at once veiled in a gauzy, unreal curtain. Every object in the lab seemed covered by a hazy glow. The Sea Witch slowly lowered her head, and in the next second she entered Dreamwalking.

…

On the Vanished, in the captain's cabin, Morris and Duncan sat beside the chart table. Not far behind them, on the wall, the old Oval Scrying Mirror showed Agatha's blurry, ghostly figure.

"Ai already flew over and confirmed it. The big island ahead really is Lightwind Harbor," Duncan said. "Right now the Vanished is hiding deep in the Spirit Realm. Before we land, we will contact Lucretia and confirm the current situation inside the city?state. As for now… the problem in front of us is still how the Vanished moved for no clear reason."

"To be honest, I have no idea," Morris said around his pipe, his brows furrowed like several cracks in a cliff. "I have heard of many 'teleportation' events. Some come from certain Visions. Some are curse anomalies like 'Sailor' at work. But what happened to the Vanished is clearly different from all of that… For now, 'the Sun going out' is the most likely cause of the Vanished's jump. Yet none of us on the ship ever noticed how it happened, or when it happened…"

"So I keep thinking that the one with a problem is not the Vanished, but the 'whole world' outside the Vanished," Duncan said in a low voice. "The news from Captain Lawrence points to the same thing—after the Sun went out, the sea changed in ways no one can understand, in places beyond our 'line of sight'. Tyrian's reports say the same."

"Has there been any new news from Mr. Tyrian?" Agatha's voice suddenly came from the mirror. "Did Cold Harbor reply?"

“…Yes. Things are developing in the strangest possible way,” Duncan nodded. “Tyrian has already checked again with the city?states that lost contact before. From their replies… the other city?states, including Cold Harbor, not only don’t know that the Sun went out, they don’t even know that their communication with Frostholm was ever cut off.”

Agatha’s expression changed slightly.

She opened her mouth and said: “So that means…”

“It means they never went through the twelve hours when the Sun was out,” Duncan said slowly. “In their eyes, the world kept running as normal. Frostholm, Pland, and Lightwind Harbor were all fine. Then, all of a sudden, Frostholm sent them a pile of strange, anxious messages about ‘the Sun going out’ and ‘communication interruptions’. Now the tension is spreading among those city?states. In Tyrian’s words, ‘they urgently need to figure out which side is actually abnormal’.”

Morris listened and thought. Then he slowly lowered his pipe. “Then we can also understand it like this. After the Sun went out, time for the whole world stopped for twelve hours. The Vanished and those three city?states were actually ‘wrongly staying normal’ during those twelve hours. It was as if, in a nightmare that everyone slept through, we… accidentally opened our eyes and saw the truth stuck in the cracks of time.”

Duncan looked thoughtful.

He had to admit that a Grand Scholar was still a Grand Scholar. Morris could not explain the rules behind all this, but he had still put forward a very enlightening guess.

Could this guess be pushed even further? In that world after the Sun went out, were there even more strange changes that no one had ever noticed? If he pushed the idea to an even more extreme point…

Was this really the first time the Sun had gone out?

These guesses floated in all their hearts, and the captain's cabin fell silent. Just then, Duncan seemed to sense something. He frowned in mild confusion: "Hm?"

"Captain?" Agatha asked at once. "Did you think of something?"

"…No, it's something else." Duncan kept his sensing posture, his state for the Listening Rite, and waved his hand. His eyes did not seem to focus. It was as if he was looking at something that was not in the room. "There is a presence…"

He suddenly looked up and stared at Morris across from him.

"What is Heidi doing right now?"

"Heidi?" Morris froze, not knowing why the captain brought this up so suddenly. "Heidi stayed in Pland. Right now they should still be in chaos over the Sun going out. City Hall will probably call her in… Is something wrong with Heidi?!"

The Grand Scholar finally reacted, and his face suddenly grew tense.

"She should not be in great danger, but the charm amulet I left her is acting a bit strange," Duncan said, frowning. Then he waved his hand at the air. A ghostly green flame flared up, and Ai's figure appeared in the air beside him. "I need a path into the dream."

…

"So what you're saying is that you were actually 'treating' someone else, and then, somehow, you ended up in my dream. Then you thought I was one of the intruders and stabbed my neck with that awl?"

The elf scholar who called himself "Taran Ael" looked very serious as he spoke slowly, watching the "golden awl" in Heidi's hand.

“Why do I feel like there are many things wrong with that story?”

“Actually…” Heidi looked very embarrassed. If anything was worse than accidentally hurting a patient with the golden awl and being caught on the spot, it was not being caught right away, only for the patient to suddenly piece it together after a while and then analyze the whole thing so seriously. This elf scholar’s reaction was far from normal. Heidi had seen many strange patients over the years, but this type was a first. “I also think it sounds wrong… but everything I said is true.”

“Everything you said is true, hmm,” Taran Ael nodded. Then he asked: “Then what about that ‘other patient’ you mentioned?”

Heidi turned at once and pointed back the way she had come. “That building is her drea…m…”

Her words trailed off, and her face went stiff.

In the direction she pointed, between the tall, lush trees and vines, the huge medical facility that had been there before… was gone without a trace.

“It’s gone…” Heidi whispered, slowly turning her head back. “But it really was there before, a very large…”

“Miss Psychiatrist,” Taran Ael cut off Heidi’s muttering. The elf scholar spread his hands, his face helpless. “You are making it very hard for me to believe you.”

—

Chapter 523: An Unexpected Meeting

Heidi admitted that, in her many years as a doctor, she had run into more tricky situations than she could count—but none had ever been as awkward as this.

However, just when she was so embarrassed that she almost pressed fingerprints into the golden awl in her hand, Taran Ael suddenly laughed.

“Even so, I still think you are telling the truth.”

Heidi looked surprised at once.

“The golden awl you use carries a very special emblem,” Taran Ael said with a smile, pointing at the “weapon” that was also a medical tool in Heidi’s hand. “Even in this dream, you still reproduced that emblem exactly. That shows you care about it a lot—Miss Heidi, you are an outstanding graduate of Truth Academy. This emblem has only ten spots each year. It is given only to the most excellent young apprentices, and it is engraved, as they wish, on one of their belongings.”

Heidi froze for a moment. Her gaze followed his finger to the end of the awl’s handle. There, an Eye of Wisdom emblem surrounded by tiny light points was carved.

An ordinary person would easily mix this emblem up with the common symbol of the God of Wisdom. Only people who truly understood the

various marks of Truth Academy could tell the difference between this emblem and a regular Eye of Wisdom.

Only then did a sudden idea flash through Heidi's mind. She stared at the elf scholar in front of her who called himself "Taran Ael." Some rough impressions in her mind finally began to piece together.

A member of Truth Academy. An elf. The old family name "Ael." Someone who would, when Visions 001 went out, do something as shocking as observe the Sun's surface…

"Taran Ael… Wait, are you that 'Mr. Taran Ael' of Lightwind Harbor?!" Heidi's eyes went wide. "The master who studies borders and hidden knowledge…"

"I don't really deserve to be called a master. I am just a researcher who stays busy all day," Taran Ael said with a wave of his hand and a smile. He was humble in words, but clearly pleased at being recognized. Then he looked a little puzzled. "You have heard of me? That is rare… I don't show my face much. I do have some fame, but only in Lightwind Harbor and among elves. How did a human from far away like you hear about me?"

"I heard about you from my father," Heidi answered at once. "I have heard about you since I was small!"

"Your father?" Taran Ael frowned.

"His name is Morris," Heidi said with a hint of pride. "Morris Underwood. When he was young, he studied at the main campus of Truth Academy, and he also studied abroad in Lightwind Harbor…"

The name felt a bit familiar to Taran Ael. After he heard Heidi's words, he remembered at once. "Ah! That young man! I remember him. He was a very gifted young man… and you are his daughter?!"

The elf Grand Scholar stared in surprise. He looked Heidi up and down several times, clicking his tongue in wonder. “Then he married and had a daughter very early…”

Heidi’s expression grew strange. She hesitated and said: “…Father was almost forty when he had me. That was already very, very late…”

“For…” Taran Ael opened his mouth, then slapped his own forehead. “Oh, sorry. I forgot I should use human standards. Sorry, I can be careless like this sometimes.”

Heidi could only give an awkward smile. She could see now that this elf scholar, whom her father praised so much, could be frighteningly thick at times…

After a brief, quiet pause, Taran Ael could not help asking with some expectation: “How did your father talk about me?”

Heidi answered without thinking: “He said that, as an elf, it was truly awe? inspiring that you managed to give yourself neck pain and frozen shoulder purely through the power of your work schedule…”

Taran Ael: “…”

Heidi: “…”

“No need to apologize,” the elf Grand Scholar said, waving his hand and cutting off the now?flustered Miss Psychiatrist. It was clear he had long grown used to similar comments. “We have chatted enough, Miss Heidi. Now it is time for you to use your professional skills and find a way to get me out of this dream.”

This perfectly timed change of topic cleared Heidi’s awkwardness at once. She quickly fixed her expression and mood and began to think about how to undo this dream.

But just as she started to recall the “professional knowledge” she had learned, Taran Ael spoke beside her: “I need to remind you first, Miss Heidi. I have already tried the Falling Method, the Suffocation Method, the Interrogation Method, and reverse hypnosis. None of them worked. All these ways could not wake me up from here. They only made me more and more awake inside the dream.”

Heidi froze for a moment and her expression changed. “More awake inside the dream?!”

“Yes. It is the most dangerous of all the dangers that follow a ‘trapped in a dream’ accident,” Taran Ael said, spreading his hands. “To grow more and more awake inside the dream and realize clearly that you are in a dream, yet still fail to wake up, means that my reason is being slowly merged into the base logic of the dream. Deep in my subconscious, I no longer believe I need to wake up. I even… subconsciously believe I already have.”

“Have you tried praying to Rahm?”

“What do you think?” Taran Ael replied with a bitter smile.

“…You are already so awake in this dream that you can even receive Rahm’s protection…” Heidi’s tone grew heavy. “So you have in fact already woken up. The terrible thing is that you ‘woke up inside the dream’… Regular mental guidance methods probably will not work.”

“How about… you try poking me with that awl again?” Taran Ael pointed at the golden awl in Heidi’s hand. “Give my subconscious a near?death hint. I can see if I can rely on the ‘Sudden?Death Method’ to go back to the Mortal Realm.”

Heidi stared for a moment, then quickly shook her head. “I don’t think that is a good idea…”

As soon as she finished speaking, a strange, slightly lazy female voice suddenly came from the side: “I also don’t think that’s a good idea, little young lady.”

Heidi jumped at the voice. She gripped the golden awl at once and looked toward the sound. A second later, a flurry of colored paper suddenly filled her vision. The falling colors swirled like snowflakes from the sky, and a graceful lady wrapped in an air of mystery stepped out from within them.

When Heidi instantly raised her guard and took a defensive stance, the mysterious lady did not even glance her way. She walked straight up to Taran Ael. “I mean it, Master Ael. Stop longing for your ‘Sudden?Death Method’. With your current health, if this Miss Psychiatrist stabs you once, you really will drop dead in the Mortal Realm.”

“Ah, Lady Lucretia!” Taran Ael’s face lit up with joy when he saw who it was. “You came to help. Well then, it seems my apprentices did not find a psychiatrist, but they did find a stronger helper. They brought the Sea Witch…”

Lucretia waved her hand. “I was the one who turned away the psychiatrist your apprentices went to find. They could not help you—right now you are in my laboratory.”

Heidi stared blankly at the scene before her. She first noticed that Taran Ael actually knew this mysterious lady. That surprised her. Then she heard the lady’s name.

Lucretia.

There might have been more than one person in the world called Lucretia, but there was only one who people called the “Sea Witch”!

Shocked, Heidi first felt a wave of tension and caution. She realized she had to say something, but when she opened her mouth, she only stammered:

“You… you are…”

“Don’t be nervous, Miss. Witches don’t eat people,” Lucretia said with a laugh, as if she found the young human lady’s reaction very amusing. “How interesting. I did not expect Master Taran Ael’s dream to have another ‘guest’. For a ‘predicament’, this place is a bit too lively.”

She spoke with a gentle smile, but bit by bit the warmth faded from it. Her eyes still seemed to smile, yet deep inside they turned cold as ice and judging.

“What is your name, strange guest?”

Heidi did not even notice the change in the warmth of Lucretia’s smile.

But her mind suddenly rang with warning. A kind of “intuition” rooted in her Spiritual Insight gift made her tense up at once!

The “witch” in front of her was analyzing her soul and mind. Lucretia was treating her as the “corruption factor” inside this dream!

The instant Heidi realized this terrible fact, she tried to put mental protection on herself. But she found that she was cut off from all supernatural powers. Even the golden awl in her hand, which was usually the closest to her, suddenly felt like something that had nothing to do with her. Under the weight of her fear and tension, she could only fight to keep her mind steady. She forced herself to think and forced out her words: “My name is Heidi. I am a psychiatrist—I entered Mr. Taran Ael’s dream by mistake. The intruders are someone else, and some of them have already been dealt with by Mr. Taran Ael himse—”

The pressure that had made her Spiritual Insight gift scream warnings vanished at once.

Heidi let out a breath of relief, but at the same time felt very confused—

She had not even finished speaking.

She lifted her head in confusion. At some point, the purple crystal pendant hanging on her chest had started to grow warm again. She pressed one hand over the crystal pendant and looked in puzzlement at the “witch” across from her.

Lucretia only frowned tightly.

“Are you a follower of my father?”

Chapter 524: The Real Intruders

Heidi first looked blank, then her face twisted in horror.

She knew who this “Sea Witch’s Father” was. That kind of chilling joke was not funny at all.

“I am a believer of the God of Wisdom Rahm, my lady,” she said in a rush, as if afraid that if she spoke a second later, the misunderstanding would deepen and she would really form some secret link with that terrifying shadow in the subspace. “I’m just an ordinary psychiatrist. You must be mistaken!”

Lucretia only frowned a little. Her calm gaze fell on the “psychiatrist’s” chest. The plain-looking purple crystal pendant there still gave off a faint, familiar aura. She might mistake other things, but Father’s aura…

Lucretia even felt that Father’s gaze was quietly resting on her through that pendant.

“This pendant of yours, where did it come from?” Lucretia suddenly asked.

“This… it was a gift from my father. He bought it from an antique shop,” Heidi explained at once, without thinking too much. “It’s nothing special, it just happens to give a bit of protection in the mental field…”

“Antique shop?” Lucretia sounded a little puzzled. “And your father is…”

“Oh, this young lady is the daughter of Morris Underwood,” said Taran Ael at last. He had been quiet at the side the whole time, but now he felt that the

mood was going in a strange direction. “Relax, Lady Lucretia. This miss really is a psychiatrist. She’s helping me get out of here.”

Lucretia froze for a second when she heard Taran Ael’s words. Then she turned to Heidi, and a strange look appeared on her face: “Morris Underwood?”

“Y-yes.” Heidi nodded. “That’s my father’s name…”

Lucretia kept her face still, but in her mind she recalled the scene from last time, when she met the new crew members of the Vanished through the scrying crystal. She remembered that respected grand scholar—her father’s current “knowledge adviser.”

The world was really small.

The coldness in her eyes faded. Her smile became sincere again, and her gaze on Heidi grew gentle: “Hello, Miss Heidi.”

“Hello…” Heidi was completely lost. In just a short moment, she felt as if her life had gone through several sharp ups and downs, yet she had no idea what was happening. She could only answer the “witch” in front of her with nervous politeness: “You… know my father? And you know Master Taran Ael too?”

“This world is smaller than you think.” Lucretia did not answer her directly. She just brushed it off, then turned to the elven scholar opposite her. “From your own sense of time, how long do you think you’ve been trapped in this dream?”

“I’m not sure. My sense of time is off now. It might be a few days… or longer.”

Lucretia frowned: “From the amount of cognitive shift, it’s already a bit dangerous… I’m guessing you already tried all sorts of waking methods yourself, including the falling method?”

Taran Ael spread his hands: “Yeah. The only thing I haven’t tried yet is the ‘sudden-death method’.”

“If the usual subconscious awakening methods don’t work, then nothing else will help. This is not a normal dream, and it’s not an external curse or a mental attack either,” Lucretia said, waving her hand. “I already checked your condition in the Mortal Realm and set up a field in the lab to control mental corruption. We can rule those out… Miss Heidi, can you tell me the information you have so far?”

Heidi blinked for a second. Two seconds later she finally reacted, and quickly told the “witch” in front of her everything she knew. She even started from the moment she accepted City Hall’s invitation in Pland, not daring to leave out a single detail.

Lucretia listened patiently to this long chain of information, her expression changing several times.

“From a dream far away in Pland, you entered Taran Ael’s dream… The distance between those two city-states is not small, and now that dream’s entrance has disappeared…” The “witch” grew solemn as she spoke slowly. “It seems that if the mental guidance isn’t smooth, even you, a psychiatrist, will end up trapped here.”

“So do you two experts have a conclusion now?” As the only “patient” present, Taran Ael was quite calm. He only sounded a bit curious. “What is this dream, really?”

“Before I draw a conclusion, I have to confirm one thing,” Lucretia said instead, her face serious. “How did you fall asleep? I found the draft you left in the tower. You seemed to be about to send it to the Academy by ‘express dispatch’. Were you attacked in the tower, or did you ‘see’ something while observing the Sun?”

Taran Ael fell into his memories.

After a long time, he spoke again, not very sure: “I wasn’t attacked… I only remember that I saw many vague shadows and lines inside the Sun, through the instruments on the tower. I wanted to record them all, but they were too messy and blurry. No matter what I did, I couldn’t see them clearly, so I could only sketch a rough outline, and then…”

His voice suddenly grew strangely hesitant. Confusion and doubt filled his eyes. The more he tried to recall what he had seen in that last moment before he fell asleep, the less sure he became of his own memory.

At last, Taran Ael stopped. He could no longer remember what happened in the final second before he blacked out. With a lost look, he slowly raised his head. His gaze passed over Heidi and Lucretia in front of him, then turned to the surroundings, to the lush and impossibly dense forest around them.

He gradually fell still. He stopped making any movement or sound at all. Even his breathing and the tiny motions of his eyes came to a complete halt. The wind that blew through the woods could no longer move his hair or the edges of his robes.

Taran Ael became a “statue” frozen in the dream.

As he fell still, the whole dream finally began to change. A strange, low rumbling spread through this world, echoing as if some vast, endless thing was slowly collapsing. The towering trees began to lose their color and break apart from the crowns downward. The lush plants all across the ground slowly weathered and crumbled, turning into drifting smoke.

Heidi stared in shock at all this, then suddenly turned to Lucretia: “This is a layer of ‘Veil’? Not the real dream?!”

“It seems you learned well at school, Miss Heidi,” Lucretia said, lifting an eyebrow. “Yes, just as I guessed. This is not a true layer of dream, but a

protective Veil woven over the dream. What we see is not really Taran Ael, but a mental construct he made for himself as a shield. No matter what we do, we can't wake him up from here—the real dream is hidden deeper down."

"Why would it be like this?" Heidi was stunned. "I… I've never seen such a real protective Veil. It covers the lower dream so completely…"

"I haven't seen anything like it either. And Taran Ael is not an expert in the mental field. He has had some special training, but in theory he shouldn't be able to weave such a perfect 'defense'," Lucretia said, shaking her head. "But one thing is sure: whoever wove this Veil is trying to hide what's in the deep layers of the dream… If Taran Ael really did this, then he must have sensed great danger after Dreamwalking…"

She suddenly stopped.

Because the "collapse" of the forest was slowing down.

It did not only stop. After a few seconds, the entire collapse began to reverse. The towering trees started to rebuild themselves one after another. Color came flooding back into the ground. The Veil that had seemed on the verge of breaking apart now started to regenerate at an amazing speed.

"The Veil is regenerating!" Heidi cried out.

Lucretia, shocked as well, at once looked toward Taran Ael's mental construct. He still stood there like a statue, showing no sign of "reactivating."

The protective Veil over this dream had regenerated, but its "weaver" was not Taran Ael. Some other power was protecting the truth in the deep layers of this dream.

The moment Lucretia realized this, two facts hit her.

First, besides the “elven maiden” Heidi had mentioned and Master Taran Ael, there was at least a third Dreamer in this dream. That Dreamer was the true controller of this “disguised dream” layer.

Second, the intruders were still nearby. The source of the corruption was right here.

The dream’s protective Veil had rebuilt itself on its own. It had sensed a great danger. That was why, even after it had already begun to fade, it suddenly reversed. From the size of this whole forest and the scale of its rebuilding, the source of that danger was far beyond what they had imagined.

Neither the Annihilator that Heidi had driven out before, nor the intruders that Taran Ael had already dealt with, were the real cause of this dream being sealed.

As Lucretia grasped this, Heidi also suddenly understood why the Veil had regenerated: “Something is hiding in this dream. The intruders are still here!”

“Look for anything strange around us!”

Lucretia called out at once, then quickly searched everything in her sight, feeling the currents in the air. She wanted to find where the “source of corruption” was hiding—the thing that this Veil was trying so hard to block out.

The air, the fragrance of flowers, the rustling of wind through the forest, the distant sound of running water, and the sunlight pouring through the canopy…

Everything felt so real. Everything felt so natural. Everything seemed perfectly normal.

Which thing, exactly, was wrong in this dream?

Wait… the sunlight?!

Lucretia’s heart jolted hard.

This forest had countless towering trees, countless thick crowns. The purpose of those crowns was to block the sunlight.

But even with so many layers of leaves, the “sunlight” still filled the whole forest. Every corner was bright.

“The sunlight is the intruder!”

She realized it at once and shouted a warning to Heidi. Heidi reflexively raised her head and, through the gaps in the canopy, looked up at the sky of this dream.

Between the overlapping crowns, many large and small openings had appeared at some point. Between those gaps lay the sky, the sunlight, and the Sun that shone on this dream.

Huge, dark, twisted tentacles coiled and wrapped together into a ball. Between them were countless enormous, pale eyes. The mass hung in the sky like some horrible freak, floating over the forest.

Bright sunlight formed a shell of living light, clear as glass, wrapped tightly around that twisted thing. From within that shell, it calmly shone on the entire dream.

Chapter 525: Attack Under the sunlight

That deformed, terrifying freak hung high over the forest, sprawling across the sky. Countless coiled and knotted tentacles held up its glowing “shell.” The “sunlight” that pierced the entire forest came from this nightmare-like intruder.

How long had it been hanging above this dream? Had it been there from the very start? Why had no one noticed how wrong the sunlight was? With what dreadful purpose was it watching this forest, patched together from several different layers of dream?

Heidi tilted her head back, as if drawn by some great force. She could not stop herself from gazing at the small “Sun” held up by those horrible limbs.

She stared at the pale giant eyes, surrounded and guarded by the tentacles.

In that instant, she felt her mind link to some vast and distant existence. Through those pale, sky-gazing eyes, something pushed straight into her thoughts. She heard a thunderous roar deep in her spirit and sensed an ancient will looking down at this dream through that blazing Sun in the sky —and at the uninvited guests inside it.

Hundreds and thousands of voices whispered or screamed in her head. Among them, she heard one voice clearly. It slipped into her awareness like a murmur from a dream:

“…hidden in the deepest part of their memories… before our sunlight goes out…”

Under that whisper boring into her mind, Heidi felt a sudden urge to submit and worship.

But in the very next second, a burning heat suddenly rose from her chest. In that heat, Heidi snapped awake. It was as if ten thousand claps of thunder exploded in her ears. She felt the link between her and those voices tear apart in an instant.

Her heart pounded like a drum. Sharp ringing filled her ears like noise. Her mind heaved wildly, and the feeling of having just escaped disaster only rose from the bottom of her heart after a few long seconds. As soon as she woke, she forced herself to tear her gaze away from the sky. At the same time, she grabbed the purple crystal pendant at her chest by reflex.

The pendant was still giving off burning heat, but it did not hurt her. Shaken, Heidi turned her head and looked at the “witch miss” standing beside her.

Lucretia was reaching her hand toward Heidi with a blank face. At Lucretia’s fingertips, three colored gems floated in the air, slowly spinning. Light leapt between the gems and her fingers, weaving a beautiful, deadly glow.

Heidi felt a jolt of fear in her heart.

“I’m awake! I’m awake!” she shouted at once, afraid that this witch really was about to act. “I’m not corrupted—”

Lucretia nodded and glanced at the crystal pendant on Heidi’s chest. The three colored gems flew back up and returned to the little ornament in her hair.

Then Lucretia paused, as if she felt she owed an explanation: “I wasn’t planning to kill you.”

“Uh…” Heidi had not expected her to say that. Her expression twitched. “I just thought you were about to do something to me.”

“It would only be a violent shock. If you had only suffered shallow mental corruption, the shock would bring up your subconscious fear of death and force the uncorrupted part of your mind to leave this dream. Afterwards, you’d at most lose some recent memories,” Lucretia explained. “That was a Dream Exit Technique Master Taran Ael invented—the ‘sudden-death method’.”

Heidi stared wide-eyed: “Didn’t you say that ‘sudden-death method’ was unreliable?!”

“It’s unreliable when used on Taran Ael himself,” Lucretia said, glancing at the grand scholar, who still stood in place like a mental statue. “He might drop dead even without nightmares.”

“Then what about me…”

“You’re sturdier.”

Heidi was speechless for a moment. She stayed awkwardly quiet for several seconds, then finally pointed up at the sky with lingering fear. During all this, she did not dare look directly at that strange, horrifying thing again. “Lady Lucretia, that thing…”

“So that’s the real intruder,” Lucretia said lightly. She swept her hand across the air in front of her. A round, illusory mirror, ringed with elegant patterns in a courtly style, appeared out of thin air before her. Using the reflection in this magic mirror, she carefully observed the scene in the sky. “The Veil in this dream exists to block that thing’s ‘gaze’.”

She paused, a thoughtful look on her face.

“It looks like the work of those cultists who worship the Black Sun. The thing in the sky looks exactly like the ‘Sunspawn’ they follow…”

“Sunspawn…” Heidi’s heart skipped. As someone from Pland and a survivor of the Black Sun incident back then, she knew better than anyone how terrible that name was. But right after that shock came a deeper confusion. “But the ‘intruder’ I first saw in the dream was clearly an Annihilator…”

“Annihilator?” Lucretia frowned. “Then… this is even worse.”

Heidi opened her mouth, about to ask what the “Sea Witch” meant. But before she could speak, a faint rustling sound suddenly came from nearby, making her fall silent at once.

“Did you hear something?” Heidi asked quickly, tense.

“Looks like the ‘protector’ of that freak in the sky has arrived,” Lucretia said calmly. “We discovered ‘it’, so ‘it’ feels fear and will try every way to wipe out any thinking beings who have seen ‘it’. The spawn of the Black Sun always behave like this—”

The rustling sound cut off.

But in the instant it vanished, a huge wave of alarm and danger surged in like a tide.

The next second, Heidi caught a flicker of shadow at the edge of her vision. Under the nearby bushes, in a spot that had seemed completely normal a heartbeat ago, a shapeless darkness began to writhe and swell. It split out cruel limbs like spearheads and blades, and lunged at her and Lucretia.

Heidi did not have time to think. Her body dropped hard to the side. At the same time, she swept the golden awl in her hand through the air in front of her. A faint afterimage stayed where she had just been. A second later, the attacker pierced that afterimage without mercy.

The dark mass snapped back, while the “figure” it had stabbed still stood where it was. The figure swayed twice. Its blurred outline quickly sharpened and turned into another “Heidi.”

At the same time, a sharp cracking blast came from Lucretia’s direction.

A shadow slithered along the ground like a vicious snake, creeping to the Sea Witch’s feet. It suddenly burst into countless thorns, spikes, blades, and tentacles. These twitching horrors surged at Lucretia from all sides, swallowing her figure in an instant.

But as those shadows crossed and tangled, Lucretia’s body suddenly transformed. She flattened into a paper-thin “image.” Her body spun once in the air and “floated” out from between those deadly attacks. Then her figure rebuilt itself on the open ground nearby. At some point, a short baton had appeared in her hand, like the baton a conductor would use when leading an orchestra on stage.

She raised the little baton and gently tapped it against a black tentacle that had formed in midair, giving a calm command:

“Minor key.”

The tentacle gave a small crack. Then more cracks followed, stringing together like notes in a song. In that stream of explosions, the tentacle broke apart into countless unreal, multicolored notes that fluttered away and vanished in the air.

All the shadows linked to that black tentacle broke into constant bursts as well. Under that terrible curse, they became a cloud of shining notes, drifting and scattering in a storm of color.

It was beautiful like a dream, and so eerie it made one’s heart race.

Lucretia flicked the conductor’s baton with grace, then turned to look at Heidi, who had already split off a third personality. There was a hint of

surprise in Lucretia's eyes.

"Your self-defense skills are pretty good. From the way you move, you've trained in the Mortal Realm too?"

"I have to know how to protect myself. In our line of work, we deal not only with mental patients, but also with their mental illness," Heidi said, panting a little, with a touch of pride. "Father always told me that a girl must learn how to protect herself." Then the look she gave Lucretia held even more awe and respect. "Your power… really is as strong as the rumors say."

"My father taught me something similar," Lucretia said with a small smile. She then turned away and calmly watched the figures that were now appearing in the air one after another.

The loss of a few tentacles and shadows did not mean things were over. For the followers of the Black Sun, their vile limbs could always stand more damage.

The true attackers finally showed themselves.

Several tall figures appeared. They wore long black coats of some unknown material, like heavy trench coats. Under the coats, something like twisted, deformed flesh kept writhing and heaving, making wet, disgusting sounds. Their faces were hidden in the shadows cast by their wide-brimmed hats. No real features could be seen, only endless emptiness and a cold hatred toward all living things.

"…Lesser spawn of the Sunspawn," Heidi said at once, recognizing what these not-quite-human beings were. She and her personality splits all shifted into guarded stances, though she could not keep from frowning. "…But I never heard that these things could invade dreams…"

Lucretia noticed something else.

“They’re not carrying umbrellas,” the Sea Witch said with a slight frown.

As an explorer who ran the border regions all year round and often dealt with all kinds of strange and dangerous powers, she was very familiar with the followers of the Black Sun and had crossed paths with them several times.

These scraps of Sunspawn that had appeared in the dream were not holding those strange, iconic black umbrellas.

They all stood openly in the light, calmly bathing in the “sunlight” that pierced the forest.

As if… exiles had returned to their home.

Chapter 526: What Was More Terrifying Than the Sunspawn…

As more Intruders appeared one after another, far more than expected, Heidi actually grew more and more nervous inside.

She knew that these not-quite-human “things” before her were far stronger than the cultist she had dealt with earlier. That cultist had only been a human who had made a contract with demons from the Abyssal Deep. Even if he had some skills, in essence he was still just a fragile mortal. Inside her own “professional field”, he had not been too hard to handle.

But these black?clad “people” were different – they were not human at all.

They were the Sunspawn’s “residue”, envoys and blood?kin split off from that misshapen terror hanging in the sky. In essence, these things were even part of the creeping Sun Wheel itself, an extension of an Elder God’s power.

These creatures had no normal mental activity and no personality structure a mortal could understand. The knowledge and techniques Heidi had as a “psychiatrist” were very limited when it came to enemies like this.

But Miss Psychiatrist still took a deep breath, calmed herself, and tightened her grip on the golden awl in her hand.

The Sunspawn did not accept negotiations with mortals. Their hatred of sentient beings was unconditional and without distinction. There was nothing to do but meet them head?on.

Besides… there was a powerful witch here. Lady Lucretia seemed to know her father. Lucretia was a bit frightening, but in a situation like this, she probably would not just watch Heidi die here… right?

That wild thought flashed through her mind and vanished. In the next second, Heidi noticed one of the black?clad “people” blur in her field of view – a sharp sense of danger crashed over her.

That blurry black shape vanished into the air. Almost at the same time, Heidi felt a stabbing pain in her abdomen. She slowly lowered her head and saw a tentacle thrust through her torso, tearing open a wound large enough to be fatal.

Only then did the attacker’s hazy figure faintly appear at the other end of that tentacle.

A golden awl stabbed over from the side. One of her personality’s avatar forms pounced toward the tentacle, driving the awl down through the air in a vicious thrust that hit that dim, hazy figure. The attacker took some damage and let out a strange shriek as it staggered back.

Heidi’s body slowly toppled to the side, but before it hit the ground, her primary consciousness had already shifted into another personality avatar form nearby. At the instant the shift finished, she swung the golden awl in that avatar’s hand, stabbing at another shadow lunging straight toward her.

At the same time, she quickly raised the revolver in her other hand, pressed the muzzle to her temple, and pulled the trigger without hesitation.

A new Personality Split appeared behind her, quickly filling the gap left by the mind entity she had just lost.

At the same time, more of the black?clad figures charged at the clearly more threatening person on the field, Lucretia. Shadows streaked through the forest as if slipping through cracks between light and dark. All kinds of

visible and invisible forces swarmed toward the spot where Lucretia stood, tearing the air, shattering the ground, and leaving behind corruption.

Lucretia’s figure, however, was like an illusion. She drifted lightly through all the attacks and quickly closed in behind one of the assailants. Before that black?clad freak could react, she had already laid a fingertip near its shoulder.

The freak let out a sharp screech. With that unbearable, piercing noise that almost no human could endure, a string of muddled words seemed to echo directly in their minds and entered the minds of both Heidi and Lucretia at the same time: “You have seen Him. You must die here!”

“ No one wants to look at your twisted, disgusting ‘kin’,” Lucretia only shook her head coldly. “Now, it is time to bloom.”

The black?clad freak suddenly raised its arm. Invisible shadows gathered inside its coat, taking on the shape of some kind of weapon, but Lucretia had already drifted back several meters.

At the spot her fingertip had tapped, a strange patch of color suddenly appeared on the “person’s” shoulder. In the next moment, that color, like spilled paint, quickly spread and came alive, turning in the blink of an eye into countless bright flowers and wildly growing vines. Thick, tangled plants grew out from inside that not?quite?human body. With the sickening sounds of flesh being torn and ground apart, they devoured this piece of Sunspawn residue in an instant.

Yet as this attacker fell, more rustling noises and the gathered breath of shadows came from all directions.

Under the sunlight, between the dense trees, several more tall figures in black coats appeared out of thin air. They gave off a weird, ominous aura as

they stepped toward Lucretia and Heidi, closing in and forming a ring around them.

And behind those figures, where the sunlight fell, even more shadows were gathering. More attackers were entering this dream.

Lucretia frowned without thinking, but before she could figure out how these attackers were flooding into this “dream” in such numbers, new attacks had already arrived.

Several black?clad freaks slipped through the seams between light and shadow and appeared beside her in an instant.

Lucretia had already been prepared. The moment the enemies appeared, the “conductor’s baton” was once again in her hand, and she pointed it at the nearest one. But just as she was about to unleash the curse, a wave of light dizziness suddenly struck and slowed her movements.

A sharp wind roared past her ear. At the instant she was about to be struck, Lucretia tore herself free of that dizziness and burst apart into countless fluttering colored paper scraps that flew to the side. Her figure then emerged from the colors, and she immediately looked toward a certain direction.

A patch of blurred, twisting smoke became visible under her gaze. The smoke swelled and writhed in the air like a strangely shaped jellyfish. From inside that jellyfish extended a pitch?black chain that reached out to a young man who was appearing out of thin air.

Almost at the same time, one of Heidi’s personality avatar forms suffered a heavy blow. An invisible force hurled her away, ripping almost half of that body apart. But before that avatar form could disperse, she still forced herself to lift her hand and fired three shots in a row at the Smokewisp Jellyfish that had appeared out of nowhere.

“ Lady Lucretia! This is the Intruder I told you about!”

“ You do not have to talk to me in such a tragic way.” Lucretia watched, expressionless, as that personality avatar form fell to the ground not far in front of her and slowly faded with eyes that could not close in peace. She could not help muttering under her breath, then suddenly raised the “conductor’s baton” in her hand to block a sharp, stabbing tentacle aimed at her. At the same time, she looked up at the Annihilator who had only now chosen to reveal himself: “So the madman who follows the Abyssal Lord has joined hands with the madman who follows the Black Sun?”

“ I originally had no intention of showing myself, but it seems our ‘temporary ally’ really does need a little help now…”

The Annihilator stood on a high spot, still wearing the blue uniform of a “medical facility staffer”, though his face had completely changed. He smiled with easy leisure as he spoke. The three shots Heidi’s personality avatar form had fired before its death had not harmed the Smokewisp Jellyfish at all. His gaze swept over the psychiatrist and the Sea Witch, who were beginning to show signs of strain under the Sunspawn residue’s siege. Then he raised his head and looked at the terrifying Sunspawn hanging in the sky, giving a small nod.

“ I hope you keep your promise. We will keep ‘digging deeper’.”

The “Sun” hanging high and still in the sky gave no response, but the “sunlight” that covered the whole forest clearly grew a few degrees hotter.

Keep your promise? Dig deeper?

Lucretia instantly latched onto those two phrases the Annihilator had mentioned, but before she could think them through, another black “residue” had already teleported to her side.

Using a sneaky blind spot, the freak lifted its arm. Several “limbs” lined with sharp blades and spikes swept sideways toward Lucretia.

Lucretia’s figure suddenly dissolved into colors and reformed a few meters away. At the same time she raised the conductor’s baton and pointed it at the enemy from afar.

Yet in the next second, the “enemy” in her eyes blurred and shifted, turning into a different figure.

Tyrian now stood there, looking toward her with a stunned expression.

“ Lucy, you are in trouble…”

But the conductor’s baton in Lucretia’s hand suddenly turned into an oversized scythe. She raised the terrible weapon high and, without the slightest hesitation, brought it down toward “Tyrian’s” head.

“ This is the best you can do?” As the enemy was sliced cleanly in two by the scythe, a few drops of blood spattered onto Lucretia’s face. She smiled, turned her head, and looked toward the Annihilator standing in the distance. “Are you so used to bullying ordinary people with weak minds that you think this will work on me?”

The Annihilator did not answer. Instead, the Smokewisp Jellyfish floating beside him suddenly contracted and swelled. At the same time, wind hissed by Lucretia’s ear. She turned her head and saw her clockwork doll Lunie, who had served her for many years, standing not far away with a dazed, frightened look.

The giant scythe rose and fell without a pause, chopping Lunie’s figure into a scattering of gears and ceramic shards. Before those disturbing fragments hit the ground, they turned into foul, filthy flesh.

In the next second, Taran Ael’s figure replaced that of a “black?clad residue” and appeared in front of Lucretia.

She again raised her hand and swung the scythe without hesitation, and as she kept swinging, she took step after step toward the Annihilator who was disrupting the battlefield.

The rabbit Rabby appeared and was cut cleanly in half without a second thought.

Lightwind Harbor’s governor, Sara Mell, appeared in front of her, and once more the scythe came down in a single stroke.

Looking at the Annihilator, who was gradually showing real panic on his face, the Sea Witch had only a trace of contempt in her eyes.

Another light crackling sound came from nearby. Lucretia looked up and saw her father appear in front of her.

She finally hesitated. The deep?rooted tension and fear almost carved into her soul made her stop for the first time.

But in the next second, she still shook her head hard, throwing off all hesitation, and raised the scythe high.

“ Your psychological attacks are improving, but they are still far from enough!”

The scythe swung down.

Lucretia did not notice the brief flash of dazed confusion on the Annihilator’s face in the distance.

She saw ghostly green flame suddenly and spontaneously ignite along the blade and haft of her scythe.

The “phantom of Father” in front of her raised his hand, caught the edge of the scythe, and looked at her in surprise.

“ Lucy, are you half?asleep?”

Lucretia froze in place.

This one… was real.

To be honest, saving up these five chapters of drafts cost me a ridiculous amount of effort…

In this past half year, things in my Mortal Realm life have kept piling up. I really had no way to keep a stable two?chapters?a?day pace, and I did not even know how much time I would have to write each day. So I thought I would try my best, and even if I could only erupt once, that would be something. I worked hard to save up some drafts, so at least it could be a bigger surprise.

Also, don’t worry, I am not taking a day off tomorrow.

And last of all, please give me a monthly ticket~~)

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Chapter 527: corruption and Dissipation

To be honest, Lucretia's mind went blank in that instant – it stayed blank for nearly two or three seconds before she slowly regained the ability to think and understood what was happening in front of her.

More terrifying than falling into a nightmare corrupted by the Sunspawn was suddenly seeing, deep in that nightmare, her father who had returned from Subspace. And even more terrifying than that was that the scythe in her own hands was chopping down toward her father's neck.

Right now, the scythe had already slipped out of her control. Dim green flame spread along its black blade and long haft. It was as if the weapon had entered another dimension and could no longer be controlled by her. Lucretia stiffly and uselessly kept her hands in the position of gripping the scythe. After holding it in for a long moment, she finally squeezed out one sentence: "Your… your scythe is really something…"

" Do you always say whatever pops into your head whenever you get nervous?" Duncan finally let go. The ghost?green flame faded as he did. "What exactly is going on here?"

As the fire died away, Lucretia finally felt that the scythe, formed from the power of the dream and the curse, had come back under her control. She hurriedly gripped it, took half a step back, and was about to answer her father's question when, in the very next second, a wave of danger suddenly surged at her from close by.

The Sunspawn’s “lesser offspring” had finally reacted, and they clearly were not going to give their enemies time to stand around and chat. In the flickering dance of light and shadow within the sunlight, several shadows lunged toward Lucretia’s back.

Lucretia had almost no time to think. She spun around, and the scythe in her hand turned into a long whip entwined with thorns. Yet just as she was about to crack the whip with all her strength, the shadows that had been pouncing at her suddenly froze in midair, revealed their true forms, and dropped to the ground as if they had lost their source of power, thrashing and struggling violently.

At the same time, Heidi, who was barely holding on by controlling several Personality Splits, suddenly felt the pressure around her ease.

She shifted her “self” from one dying personality avatar form into another that was still in decent shape. Then she stared in shock as the black?clad figures around her all collapsed one by one, flopping weakly on the ground like fish being seared by a blazing sun and struggling through their last moments.

The depths of their black coats, made of some unknown material, kept swelling and writhing. Their horrible limbs began to rot and fall apart at high speed. With sickening noises, a foul stench and filthy pus slowly spread out from under their bodies.

Even as a professionally trained psychiatrist, Heidi could not help backing up two steps in the face of this scene. Then she seemed to sense something and instinctively raised her head, wanting to look at the sky – but the instant she started to look up, she forced herself to stop.

The horror she had felt the last time she looked up and saw the Sunspawn was still carved deep into her mind, keeping her from checking her guess.

Just then, she heard the stranger who had suddenly appeared in front of Lucretia say to her: “It is all right. The sky is safe now.”

For some reason, that sentence seemed to carry a powerful force. Even though she had no reason at all to believe it, a strong impression still rose in Heidi’s heart at once: the sky was safe now.

She slowly lifted her head and looked at the “Sun” hanging high above the forest, shining and burning.

That “thing” was still quietly floating above the trees. Countless twisted tentacles and pale eyes piled together like a clump of flesh that had grown however it pleased. Its light was like blazing flame, rising and burning across the surface of that grotesque mass. Yet in the depths of that fire, a faint green slowly spread and quickly covered the surface of the whole entity.

At the moment she saw those twisted tentacles and pale eyes, fear surged uncontrollably in Heidi’s heart. But very soon she realized that her mind had not suffered any corruption from seeing it this time.

The Sunspawn’s corruption seemed to be blocked by the spreading ghostly green light – or rather, that light was corrupting and assimilating the corruption, making it harmless.

The dying struggles and screams of the “lesser offspring” clawed at Lucretia’s eardrums. Those black, almost?human inhuman things were dying quickly under the altered sunlight, dissolving as if they were soaking in strong acid. Confused, she watched this scene and turned to Duncan: “What is happening?”

“ I corrupted their temporary Sun,” Duncan said calmly. “Now, this sunlight is ‘poisonous’ to them. This is something I learned from the ‘Black Sun

incident’ in Pland – this kind of residue can only survive under a specific kind of sunlight.”

Duncan spoke with a calm expression, then lifted his head and turned his gaze on the twisted being still floating above the forest.

He thought of the Black Sun he had once glimpsed through the Golden Sun Mask, and of that pale Elder God dying under the burning of the corona. Compared to the Black Sun he had seen back then, the thing now hanging over this dreamscape was clearly much smaller and far weaker.

So… this must be the “Sunspawn” those mad cultists kept talking about.

Now, this Sunspawn was being quickly devoured by the flames of corruption. The light and heat it gave off were being transformed into something that could burn it away. Yet this eerie, terrifying “creature” showed not the slightest reaction of pain. It only hung high in the sky, quiet and silent, as if it did not have emotions like pain or fear at all.

It simply shone and gave off heat, just like… a real Sun.

Yet when Duncan gazed at its pale eyes with his gaze, he still felt that the thing had thoughts. It was thinking. It was watching. It had a purpose and a will. It was not like the dying Black Sun, which had only wanted to extinguish itself, nor like the mad cultists, who only wanted to destroy the entire world.

What was this “creature” thinking right now?

“ What are you thinking?” Duncan could not help asking in his heart.

“ May I go back now?” In the blurred message that came back along the ghostly flames, he heard a voice, calm and gentle. “There is nothing here that I want.”

Duncan’s eyes widened slightly for a moment.

In the next instant, just as he tried to establish more contact with the Sunspawn, a hollow boom suddenly came from the sky. The burning mass of fire seemed to collapse inward, shrinking at once into a small point. A heartbeat later, the ghostly flames that had lost their target burst apart and scattered.

The “false Sun” that had been overlooking the forest vanished.

A dim, faintly reddish light took the place of the bright “sunlight” that had filled the sky a moment before, and the whole forest sank into a dusk?like gloom.

Lucretia’s surprised voice came from the side: “Did you destroy it?”

“ No.” Duncan shook his head slightly and shared the information he had sensed just now. “It left. That was not its true body, only a projection formed by a Sunspawn inside the dream, like a tendril used for sensing. Now it has pulled that tendril back out of the dream.”

Lucretia nodded thoughtfully, but soon she suddenly realized something else: “Wait, what about that Annihilator just now?!”

“ He ran,” Duncan said casually. “While those ‘lesser offspring’ were dying, he was constantly lowering his own presence. Then, when that false Sun in the sky collapsed and faded, he slipped away in the chaos.”

At this, Lucretia immediately frowned and instinctively scanned the forest, now dim as dusk. “Damn… I actually let my attention get dragged away. I should have left a curse on him…”

“ It is fine,” Duncan just waved his hand. “Let him run for a while.”

Lucretia was stunned for a moment when she heard this and lifted her head to look at Duncan: “You… let him go on purpose?”

Duncan did not answer her directly. He narrowed his eyes slightly as if sensing something, then smiled and shook his head. “Either way, he has already seen me.”

He did not pay any mind to the brief change on Lucretia’s face. Instead, he turned toward Heidi, who was standing tens of meters away, nervous and trying her best to make herself less noticeable.

He walked up to Miss Psychiatrist – or rather, to the whole crowd of Heidis – and first checked her condition.

About seven or eight Heidis were covered in wounds of all sizes. Three of them were horribly injured, lying on the ground and flopping like dying fish. Their personality parts had clearly withdrawn, leaving only a few last reflexive spasms. Two Heidis still looked to be in decent shape. One of those stood there with a blank expression, while the other nervously avoided Duncan’s gaze.

Duncan swept his eyes over the “large crowd of Heidis” without changing his expression, and silently sighed to himself. The psychiatrists of this world had truly taken a wild path. When they split their minds, it was even more “split” than actual schizophrenia. Then he walked right past the “Heidi” whose face was tense and whose eyes were dodging, and stopped in front of the blank?faced Miss Psychiatrist.

“ Are you all right?”

The blank “personality avatar form” jolted, and vivid expression suddenly came back to her face: “How did you know…”

By now she had, of course, guessed who this tall, imposing figure was, the one who made people feel endless pressure. She had been nervous to the point of breaking, planning to hide behind a personality avatar form to

avoid having to face this terrifying Subspace Shadow directly. She had not expected her trick to fool him for even a second.

“ You use Personality Splits to protect yourself when you are nervous,” Duncan said with a friendly smile. “Although I really did not expect your Personality Splits to be this… impressive. Now I am very impressed.”

“ Sometimes… patients with schizophrenia can be hard to deal with. If you do not split enough, you cannot beat them…” Heidi explained without thinking, then suddenly realized something. “Wait, how did you kno…”

Duncan smiled and raised a hand, pointing at the purple crystal pendant on Heidi’s chest.

“ Strictly speaking, I am the one who gave you that pendant.”

Chapter 528:

“The pendant?”

When she heard the words of the Subspace shadow in front of her, Heidi was stunned at first. Then she lowered her head and looked at the “amethyst” pendant on her chest, the one that had come from some glass workshop. In the next second, everything about that pendant rose up in her mind—

The strange antique shopkeeper.

The pendant her father had brought back from the antique shop.

The impossible protection it gave during the Black Sun incident.

The second pendant.

Vanna’s unfinished investigation of that antique shop.

And now… the appearance and words of Duncan Abnomar…

Miss Psychiatrist slowly widened her eyes. Her wild guesses slowly turned into solid fact. She suddenly felt… that she might need some psychological help herself.

“Relax a little, and also control where you look. Don’t stare at things you shouldn’t,” Duncan said to Heidi with a slow smile. “Your father asked me to remind you of that.”

Heidi felt her head buzzing. She could not tell if it was noise from mild mental corruption, or just hallucinations born from nervous tension. She

held her forehead and finally forced her reason and impulses under control, but her thoughts still felt slow and broken: “My father… where is he now…”

“He is serving as an adviser on the Vanished. He was afraid you would worry, so he never told you. None of us thought you would get dragged into this mess so muddle-headedly.”

“Is he all right?! He is on your ship…” Heidi blurted out. But when she looked at the stern-faced “captain” in front of her, her voice suddenly faltered. No matter how she asked, it all felt rude and reckless right now.

Duncan did not mind at all. He answered casually: “He is fine. He keeps the healthiest schedule on the crew, and he plays a huge role on the ship. Anything else you want to know?”

Heidi opened her mouth. Words shuffled in her mind for a long time before another matter suddenly came to her. It had happened almost at the same time her father walked out of the house, and now it seemed full of holes. Her guess felt insane, but she still could not hold back from asking: “Then… is Vanna also on your…”

Duncan did not answer directly, but he confirmed her guess from the side: “Do you want to see them?”

Heidi froze for a moment and suddenly did not know how to answer this simple question. Only after two or three seconds did she jolt back to herself. Her first reaction was to put away that whole crowd of terrifying Personality Splits, then she spoke in a panic: “Is that allowed? You really permit it? Ah, sorry, I don’t mean anything else, but I heard a lot about you… I should…”

Her flustered words suddenly stopped.

Because, along with a rotating doorway of ghostly green flame, two very familiar figures had already appeared in front of her—

Morris wore a smile, while Vanna's face looked a bit awkward.

"So, uh… long time no see," Vanna walked up to Heidi, rubbed the tip of her nose, and greeted her. "Sorry I kept it from you for so long. The new post is kind of sensitive, and there are secrecy rules. I only got to come this time because the captain said yes… Are you mad?"

Heidi did not answer. She only stared wide-eyed at this friend of many years, then stared wide-eyed at Morris beside her. She held it in for a long time before finally blurting out: "Can one of you please explain in detail what on earth is going on?!"

"I'll let you talk," Duncan saw that they had started to talk and sensibly waved his hand, then turned and left. "I'll go talk with Lucy."

He left the two crew members and Heidi standing there, staring at each other with wide eyes, the awkwardness almost spilling over.

Duncan paid no attention to the faintly resentful air that flashed between Vanna and Morris behind him. He walked straight over to Lucretia, only to see the "Sea Witch" avoiding his eyes, looking rather embarrassed.

Lucretia had been thinking hard for a long time. Ever since Father suddenly entered this dream, she had been in a state of confusion and helplessness. While Father went to talk with that "psychiatrist" just now, she had been trying to decide how to talk to this "relative" she had not seen in so many years, how to adjust her mindset like Tyrian had, and…

How to explain that swing of her scythe just now.

Yet when Father really walked over, she realized she had not prepared anything at all. The "Witch" who made so many people fear her on the Boundless Sea was actually not good at dealing with sudden emotional

scenes like this. Because of all the wild thoughts she had just had, she felt even more at a loss now.

Lucretia opened her mouth: “I…”

“No rush,” Duncan suddenly waved his hand, cutting off whatever Lucretia was about to say. Then he turned to look at Heidi and the other two not far away. “Let’s watch for a while.”

Lucretia: “…?”

She was a bit lost for a moment. She did not know what Father meant by “watch for a while”. She even started to think of words like “plan” and “scheme”, which were not what he meant at all. But the next second, she saw that the familiar yet long-absent figure beside her was simply looking into the distance with a very human, watching-the-show kind of expression.

The Sea Witch hesitated, then also looked that way. A strange feeling rose in her heart. She did not know how to describe this odd and awkward turn of events—this was nothing like the scene she had imagined for many years about meeting Father again.

She had imagined that one day in the future, her undying self might, like Tyrian, also meet the Vanished returning from Subspace. She had imagined a brutal clash between the shining stars and the Vanished, that evil spirit from Subspace destroying all the traitors, just like he had once destroyed the Viseran Thirteen Isles on the border…

And in some gentler dreams, in fantasies that had nothing to do with reason, she had also imagined another scene—

Father would really come back. It might be on a quiet afternoon, or in the last light before dusk. They might stand on a sea cliff, like that place they had gone to in her childhood. She no longer remembered which city-state it was, only the mild sea breeze and white flowers everywhere. She and her

family would stand on the highest rock. Father would tell her about the things that had happened in distant places, and she would proudly show off her Radiant Star, all her laboratories, and all her books…

But those broken dreams had all melted away in the sunlight, like sighs fading into the wind.

She had never thought that when the day of reunion really came, it would look like this—she and Father standing in this dream that seemed endless, together…

Watching other people's drama.

But little by little, Lucretia seemed to understand Father's intent.

She also looked that way, at Miss Psychiatrist with her family and friend. Over there was another daughter full of worries, a father trying to explain everything through his embarrassment, and even a friend who did not know what to do.

Maybe this was what Father meant by letting her "watch for a while".

Lucretia felt that she understood.

Then she heard Duncan break the silence beside her: "Actually, I tried to talk Morris into telling Heidi earlier, but we never found the right chance. Still, this works too. If he had explained everything before, I wouldn't have anything to watch now."

Lucretia felt she had understood too early.

In her brief confusion, she suddenly remembered something Tyrian had said in one of their earlier talks—

Father had found his humanity again.

But it seemed he had found a bit too much.

Back then she could not understand what her brother meant. Now she vaguely got it. The being that had returned from Subspace might be her father, but he was no longer only that.

“Lucy, what do you think?”

Duncan’s voice suddenly came from beside her, cutting off Lucretia’s wild thoughts. She jolted awake and looked at Father, who was now giving her a questioning look.

The messy thoughts in her mind quickly calmed down. The clash between old memories and what she saw now was thrown aside. The Sea Witch suddenly felt that all those tangled questions were not really problems. The person in front of her… was fine just like this.

After all, life was not academic research. Not every question had to have an answer.

“Miss Heidi will handle everything. I haven’t worked with her much, but I know she is rational. And there is even less need to worry about Mr. Morris. He is an adviser you trust…”

“Oh, I didn’t mean them. I meant this ‘place’,” Duncan waved his hand and pointed at the forest around them, which had fallen into dusk yet showed no sign of breaking apart. “This should be a dream, right? But it looks strange. It’s not like any dream I’ve seen…”

Lucretia felt a little off for a moment. Father’s thoughts now seemed to jump around, very different from the man in her memory. But she quickly adjusted, hurriedly sorting out her thoughts and pulling her attention away from the distant drama. She spoke while she thought: “The ‘entrance’ to this dream is Scholar Taran Ael, the mind entity over there that’s still frozen. His ‘self’ has not woken up yet. The story began like this…”

Lucretia laid out all the information she had as briefly as she could. Duncan listened carefully, then showed a thoughtful look.

“So, this forest is only a barrier that covers the ‘surface’ of the dream. The dream’s real form is hidden much deeper. And the one behind all this isn’t that elf named Taran Ael, but the ‘third Dreamer’.”

“The third, but there could also be a fourth or a fifth,” Lucretia said seriously. “Heidi’s experience shows that this dream is ‘connected’ to somewhere else. That means it could be connected to even more Dreamers. But all of that has been hidden. This forest’s ability to ‘heal itself’ and to ‘hide’… is far beyond what we imagined.”

Duncan said nothing. He frowned and sank into thought.

Just then, out of the corner of his eye, he saw the “Grand Scholar Taran Ael” not far away suddenly blink.

Chapter 529:

In the middle of the forest clearing, the mind entity of Taran Ael, which had been frozen because of “Protective Descent”, suddenly blinked. It seemed that as the corruption from the creeping Sun Wheel faded, his self-awareness finally returned to this shallower layer of the dream.

Duncan and Lucretia noticed at once and both walked toward the elven scholar. In just two or three seconds, he fully woke and stared in shock at the scene before him.

Nothing was quite the same as in his memory. The forest that had been lit by sunlight had somehow fallen into a strange dusk. Shadowy darkness blurred the sky, and many new figures had appeared in his view. He did not know any of them (including Morris, whom he had not seen for decades).

After looking around in confusion, Taran Ael finally gave a little start. He hesitated, then broke the silence: “Is my condition really this serious?”

Lucretia, who had just walked up, froze when she heard him: “What are you talking about?”

Taran Ael pointed at himself, then at Heidi, Vanna, and Morris, who had noticed the commotion and were walking over. His face was full of disbelief. “I was only out for a little while. How did it turn into this many people doing a consultation?”

Lucretia’s expression twitched. She almost lost her composure.

But Taran Ael kept talking: “If you really can’t wake me up, let me try my own method. The ‘Sudden-Death Method’ is actually quite effective…”

As soon as Lucretia heard that, she quickly cut off the Grand Scholar: “Stop thinking about your ‘Sudden-Death Method’. Do you know what just happened?”

“Just now?” Taran Ael looked blank. “What happened just now? I just zoned out…”

“The Black Sun’s minions invaded your dream and even brought in a projection of a Sunspawn,” Lucretia said with a serious face, watching Taran Ael’s expression as she spoke. “You didn’t sense any of it? If my father hadn’t appeared in time, the mind entity you left here might already have been destroyed by the battle’s aftershocks.”

Taran Ael’s face had already grown serious as he listened to the first half of Lucretia’s words. But when he heard the last sentence, he suddenly froze. Then he slowly started to react, turning his head toward Duncan with a hesitant and horrified look as he spoke: “Your… father?”

Lucretia nodded in silence. Duncan tried his best to show a friendly smile and reached out his hand to this respected Grand Scholar: “You can just call me Captain Duncan.”

But Taran Ael did not take his hand. His whole body seemed to go rigid as he stared wide-eyed at the tall figure before him. Then he suddenly drew in a deep breath, his whole form giving a violent “shudder”, and his figure vanished from the forest.

Duncan stared, completely baffled, then turned and asked: “What just happened?”

Lucretia looked almost as stunned. It took her two or three seconds after Duncan spoke to realize what had happened. Then she said, with a strange

look: “…The ‘Sudden-Death Method’ worked.”

Duncan: “…?”

Just then, Heidi, Vanna, and Morris also walked over. They had planned to greet their awakened Master Taran Ael, but only saw him vanish into thin air and heard Lucretia’s last mutter. Their faces all changed in different ways.

Heidi’s face was full of amazed wonder, as if saying, “That actually worked.” Morris’s eyes held a trace of regret. Only Vanna just looked blank—she was the Athlete and did not really understand what these psychology experts were doing.

Whenever she ran into a nightmare, she just cut her way through it and ran out.

“I wanted to say hello to Master Taran Ael,” Morris said with regret. “We haven’t seen each other for many years.”

“He wouldn’t have recognized you,” Heidi shook her head. “In his memory, you’re still a young man studying abroad. He can’t even imagine that you now have a daughter.”

Morris thought for a moment and sighed softly: “That’s what it’s like dealing with elves.”

“Looks like you cleared things up?” Duncan glanced at the mood among the three and asked curiously.

“We did,” Vanna nodded and spread her hands helplessly. “We got scolded for a long time.”

Heidi kept quiet. She could not help carefully studying the “famous” captain in front of her. Her gaze moved back and forth between the people

present, and who knew how many wild thoughts rushed through her mind in those few seconds.

Lucretia was not paying attention to them. She had been carefully watching the changes in this “forest” since just now. At this moment she finally broke the silence in a low voice: “Just as I guessed, Taran Ael has woken up, but the ‘dream’ itself still exists… There is another ‘Dreamer’ keeping this place going.”

Hearing her, Duncan only nodded lightly.

Because he still could not tell what kind of “Dreamer” lay behind this dream, and because this place seemed to link to many ordinary people, he had not “set it on fire” here. But ever since then, he had been carefully sensing this place.

This forest, which looked utterly real, was in essence a dream. Behind it should be the Dreamer’s subconscious. By entering here through “Spirit Realm walking”, he should in theory be able to touch and even sense that “subconscious”, just like when he had touched those “starlights” while walking in the Spirit Realm before and felt emotions and rough scraps of thought.

But here, no matter how far he extended his senses, no matter how carefully he used the “Listening Rite”, he could only feel a vast… emptiness.

There was nothing. No fear, no thoughts. Beyond the forest was still forest. Deep under the ground was still ground. The Dreamer’s personality was nowhere to be found. Rather than a “barrier” made by a subconscious to protect the deep layers of the dream, this forest felt to Duncan more like a mass of chaotic mist.

A barrier had a purpose. But mist just gathered here on its own in chaos. It had no purpose and no awareness. It only followed some ancient rule.

Duncan kept wondering what lay behind this empty, vast dream. Just then, a gust of disorderly wind suddenly blew out from deep in the forest. The cold that came with it cut off his thoughts.

“…This forest is starting to reject us,” Heidi said at once, frowning, though her tone held some doubt. “But why didn’t it react before?”

“Maybe because Taran Ael woke up,” Lucretia said thoughtfully. “His waking did not make the dream break apart, but it did close one ‘entrance’. So of course we uninvited guests will be pushed out.”

“Looks like it’s time to leave,” Duncan sighed with regret. His instincts told him this dream still hid many secrets. But he also knew that if he forced himself to stay after the dream had started to push them out, the damage he caused might not be any less than that ‘twisted Sun’ in the sky from before.

“That’s fine. I need to get back to the Mortal Realm soon and check on Taran Ael’s condition,” Lucretia said. She actually looked a bit relieved. “I really don’t want him dying on my ship.”

“All right, go,” Duncan nodded to her. “We can talk about the rest when we meet in the Mortal Realm. I’ll come find you soon.”

Lucretia’s face seemed to tighten for a moment, but she quickly eased and showed a small smile. “All right, but there’s no rush. It’s fine if you take your time. It’s a long voyage from Frost Sea to the southern seas, so be sure to travel sa—”

“I mean I’ll be there very soon—probably this afternoon,” Duncan waved his hand. “The Vanished is already near Lightwind Harbor.”

Lucretia’s smile froze at once. “…Huh?”

Duncan stayed calm. “Maybe it’s some effect from the Sun going out. The Vanished crossed a huge distance in an instant. I’m already there now.”

Lucretia stared for a beat. Then her figure “flickered” twice and vanished into thin air in front of everyone.

Duncan, Heidi, and the others were left staring at one another.

The awkward silence lasted for a moment. At last Vanna spoke first: “Did she scare herself awake?”

No one answered her.

“Time to go,” Duncan shook his head, easing the sudden awkwardness. “If you have anything else to say, we can talk later.”

Their short reunion had already reached the moment of parting again. A hint of sadness rose in Heidi’s heart. She looked at her father and friend standing beside Captain Duncan, her feelings mixed, and suddenly thought of something: “Wait, how am I supposed to contact you?! You’re on the Vanished…”

“Just write letters,” Morris said with a smile. “Send them straight to that antique shop in the Lower City. The captain will hand them over himself.”

“Huh? Just write letters?”

Heidi froze for a moment. Before she could react, she heard Vanna speak beside her: “If it’s just a short message, you can also go to the Cathedral. Bishop Valentine can help pass it on.”

Heidi still looked dazed. “You mean the Cathedral?!”

“Or you can wait until the ship has a holiday,” Duncan added next. “We’ve been busy lately, but there should be a break later. I can send them back to Pland then.”

“The Vanished even has holidays?!”

However, none of Heidi’s questions got a reply.

The wind from the forest was growing clearly cold and hostile. The dream's rejection was reaching its peak. In Heidi's eyes, Captain Duncan, her father, and Vanna were all starting to blur.

At last, even her own consciousness turned dim and hazy, and she sank into darkness in a sudden wave of weightlessness.

A second later, the darkness faded, and she jolted awake from the dream.

Heidi opened her eyes and saw that she was lying on a bed in a ward of some medical facility. Her original "patient" was nowhere to be seen.

It seemed that after she fell into Dreamwalking, someone had noticed the Anomaly and brought her here.

Miss Psychiatrist let out a deep breath.

This long and winding dream had finally come to an end.

Chapter 530: The Uninvited Guest

For the first few minutes, Heidi did not rush to get up from the hospital bed. She carefully watched her surroundings and listened to the sounds outside the room. Then she lifted her wrist and checked the number and color order of the little stones on her bracelet.

After that, she unconsciously reached to touch the amethyst pendant on her chest. A faint chill came from the gem to her fingertips, carrying a quiet, reassuring strength.

As she thought of the pendant's true origin and the source of this Protective Ward, Miss Psychiatrist's expression turned a little strange. But she quickly pushed that odd feeling down, leaving only a helpless sigh in her heart.

She could not help murmuring softly: "Fate really is unbelievable…"

"Yes, in your eyes, fate truly is unbelievable."

A strange, low voice suddenly came from her side. Heidi snapped awake at once, and all her muscles tightened.

She jerked her head toward the sound. By the ward's window, a figure in an old dark-brown robe was sitting there, though she had no idea when he had appeared. The worn robe hid almost all the lines of his body. A thick, wide hood covered his face completely in shadow. From his hunched posture, his deep voice, and the faint wrinkles at the edge of the hood's shadows, one could only guess that he was an old man.

sunlight slanted in through the window. Tiny specks of dust floated slowly in the evening light. The rays fell across the folds of the stranger's robe, leaving broken, mottled shadows. For a moment, his figure seemed almost like a half-transparent phantom.

Who was this? When had he appeared here? Had he been here all along?

A string of unnerving questions flashed through Heidi's mind. At the same time, her hand moved on its own toward the trunk beside the bed.

But before her fingers touched the trunk, that low, hoarse voice came again from the window: "There is no need for so much hostility, Miss Heidi. Today I am not your enemy—and your golden spike and pistol cannot kill a temporary traveler. Sit down. I only came to talk with you, to help ease your boredom."

Heidi's face stayed expressionless. She still drew the pistol from the hidden compartment in the trunk, quietly lifted it, and pointed the muzzle at him. Her voice was low and cold: "…What are you?"

The robed figure did not answer Heidi. Instead, he slowly raised his arms and examined his hands carefully in the sunlight falling through the window, as if he had just found something very interesting. He moved his arms back and forth in the sunlight, observing them again and again.

The sleeve of the old robe slipped down. The arm beneath was dry like a dead branch, the skin wrinkled and cracked.

Heidi watched this strange behavior, her face tense with alertness. Then she suddenly noticed the eerie state of that arm in the sunlight—it really did become transparent from time to time. For a few brief instants she could even see the sunlight pass through his arm and shine directly onto her side.

"How unbelievable… I had almost forgotten what sunlight looked like…"

The robed man sounded full of wonder, his tone carrying a hard-to-name emotion. Then he suddenly turned his head. It sounded as if he was speaking to Heidi, yet also as if he was simply talking to himself: "… Before the Fourth Long Night begins, things will change. sunlight will grow gentle. The sharp 'boundary' that sunlight once drew will blur. What was exiled, what was forgotten, what was erased, what was changed will, for a short time, be allowed to return to this world. We will bathe together in this dusk and wait for the moment when the Sun sets…"

His low voice flowed on. Rather than speaking to any living person, it sounded more like he was facing a finished book, slowly reading out the ancient words already written there.

Like a preacher, proclaiming fate to the world.

As Heidi listened to his chant, which seemed to hold some strange charm, a thought stirred faintly in her mind. Her gaze sharpened at once: "Ender?!"

The robed figure finally raised his head. In the dim shadows beneath the hood, a pair of eyes glowed with an eerie golden light. They rested on her calmly, like a gaze: "Miss Heidi, you have established a connection with that Promised Ark. Did you see the End of that journey?"

"I have no interest in a cultist's temptation." Heidi's voice was hard and cold. Her finger pressed a little tighter on the trigger, while her other hand unconsciously clutched the amethyst pendant at her chest. A nervous tension slowly spread from her heart.

She had no real confidence. She had dealt with psychiatric patients and their illnesses. She had fought monsters and shadows from nightmares. But she had never faced a "rare enemy" like a Ender. The mortal world had very few records on these Subspace madmen. The self-defense courses at Truth Academy's attached martial school had no special training against this kind

of cultist. She did not know how much use her pistol would be, nor whether the supernatural power she commanded would work at all.

Yet the uninvited guest showed no reaction at all to her obvious hostility.

He seemed very different from the Enders described in the textbooks Heidi had studied.

“We smelled something unusual, Miss Heidi, right after the Promised Ark arrived,” he said slowly, even politely. “A huge, boundless void. It appeared after the End. There was nothing there… We have been seeking a way to avoid Doomsday. But now it seems that beyond Doomsday lies an emptiness far more terrifying than Doomsday itself… You have come into contact with It. Now you have become a part of that void as well. This makes us very curious… What exactly happened?”

His words sounded rambling and obscure, like one mute riddle after another. It was as if he still possessed reason, yet after a long and chaotic stretch of time had completely lost the ability to speak normally with an ordinary person. Even so, Heidi still caught some vague bits of information from his scattered phrases, and her feelings could not help but stir.

She frowned slightly.

“You mean… Duncan Abnomar? You’re saying he brought some kind of ‘void’?”

The old preacher slowly rose from the chair. In the sunlight, he proved taller than Heidi had imagined. Even with his hunched back, he stood like a giant. “I don’t know. We only know that the void has appeared, and that it is growing. Perhaps one day, it will cover the whole night sky of the Fourth Long Night…”

Heidi tensed at his sudden movement and raised her pistol a little higher. “Heretic, what do you want from me?”

“…We desperately want to know the nature of this void,” he actually answered her question seriously. But soon he shook his head. “Sadly, it seems I did not come at the right time.”

Heidi paused in surprise and blurted out: “What do you mean?”

The other man did not answer. He only turned slowly and looked at the sunlight outside the window.

“You just mentioned the Fourth Long Night. What does that mean?” Heidi asked quickly.

The uninvited guest only waved his hand.

“In this Window Interval, we can only exchange a little,” the Ender said softly, stepping toward the sunlight. “The time to leave has come. We may meet in the next Window Interval, or we may not. That depends on how fast the void expands… But no matter whether another window appears or not, we will meet again sooner or later… dusk is near.”

His figure finally became completely transparent and, in the next instant, melted into the sunlight.

Heidi froze.

If her memory had not been so clear and firm, if the solid feel of the pistol and the amethyst pendant in her hands had not been so definite, she would almost have thought she had fallen into yet another dream.

Then, as the Ender’s presence vanished completely, she suddenly felt that the “atmosphere” in the room had changed in a subtle way.

It was as if some sealing power had faded from the room.

Hurried footsteps sounded in the corridor outside the ward.

…

On the Vanished, in the captain’s cabin, Duncan sat quietly at the chart table. He was still thinking over the information he had seen and sensed in that strange dream earlier.

He did not know how much time had passed before Morris’s voice suddenly came from the side, breaking his thoughts: “I thought you would consider letting Heidi join this ship.”

Duncan looked up and smiled at the old gentleman: “Didn’t you say before that you didn’t want her getting too close to the Vanished?”

“At the time… I was still a bit nervous about this ship,” Morris answered with an embarrassed little smile. Then he shook his head. “And back then, Heidi knew nothing about us. Now that she already knows, there’s no need to keep her at such a distance.”

Duncan thought for a moment and spoke quite seriously: “True. But when I thought it over, it seemed this ship doesn’t really need a psychiatrist.”

He turned his head and glanced out the window, then said casually: “Who here needs counseling? You don’t. Agatha doesn’t. I certainly don’t. Vanna’s will is so strong it even shocks me. Shirley’s sanity is bound to Dog, and Dog is a Abyssal demon. Nina is a fragment of the Sun. Alice… Alice doesn’t have a scheming bone in her body. Anyone else? Goathead?”

Goathead, lying on the chart table, snapped his neck around the moment he heard his name: “Ah, great Captain, your First Mate is forever steadfast and reliable, and will never be beaten by so?called psychological problems. I even self?studied many courses in psychology, so I can fully—”

“Shut up.”

“Oh.”

“So, you see,” Duncan turned to Morris and spread his hands, “if Heidi did come aboard, the one most likely to need a psychiatrist on this ship would

probably be Heidi herself.”

Morris considered it for a while. He quietly picked up his pipe and muttered before putting it to his lips: “That does seem true…”

Chapter 531: The Grand Scholar Awakens

Lucretia tore herself out of the dream in a sudden jolt. Even so, she spent several seconds calming her thoughts before opening her eyes. Only then did she let out a long breath, open her eyes on the chair, and slowly look around the room to check the “hint items” she had set up in advance in the laboratory.

The first thing to do after waking from a strange dream was never to jump up at once. One had to calm the mind first and confirm the details of the Mortal Realm, to avoid being trapped inside a double dream.

After a short while, she confirmed the details of the Mortal Realm and that she had completely left that dream. At the same time, she confirmed that Master Taran Ael had woken up as well.

The elven Grand Scholar was in a sorry state. Several ropes tied him to a nearby pillar, and a lump had risen on his head. The clockwork doll Lunie stood next to him with a sharp kitchen knife in hand, watching him with full attention.

“Lady Lucretia, you’re finally awake!” The Grand Scholar cried out for help the moment he saw the Sea Witch open her eyes. “Your servant tied me up! I don’t know what I did wrong…”

Lucretia frowned at once: “Lunie, what is this about?”

“He suddenly started yelling in his sleep,” Lunie reported, still gripping the kitchen knife and looking very serious. “After he woke up, he jumped off the bed and hit his head on your workbench. I judged that he had been corrupted by a nightmare, so I tied him up to prevent secondary injuries.”

The Grand Scholar protested loudly: “How many times have I told you, you wooden head! I was only scared in a dream! I saw Duncan Abnomar! As a normal, sane ordinary person, am I not allowed to wake up in fright when I see him in a dream?”

Listening to the “two people” in front of her, Lucretia’s expression twisted a little. She had also just been frightened awake. She pressed her lips together and rose from the chair: “Lunie, put down the knife and untie the scholar. He is telling the truth.”

“Yes, Mistress.” The clockwork doll bowed her head at once. With a clean downward swing of the knife, she cut through the ropes on Taran Ael’s body. Then she flipped her wrist, and the cold, gleaming blade disappeared into some hidden compartment inside her.

Free again, Taran Ael stumbled forward two steps before he finally found his balance. He could not help turning to glare at the stiff doll: “You wooden head!”

The clockwork doll paid no attention at all to the Grand Scholar’s anger. She simply stepped to her Mistress’s side and asked curiously: “Has the old Master arrived?”

“He… ‘arrived’, in every sense of the word,” Lucretia said, the corner of her mouth twitching slightly, her tone a bit hesitant. Then she waved one hand. A chair floated out from the corner of the room and landed in front of her. “Mr. Taran Ael, sit down. I have some things I need to ask.”

Taran Ael stretched his sore arms, grumbling as he walked over to sit in front of the Sea Witch. He muttered to himself: “If he’s coming, then he’s coming. It’s not as if he could get here in an instant anyway…”

Lucretia listened to his muttering in silence and said nothing. She only reached toward a low cabinet at her side, felt around deep inside, and took out a bottle of potion, which she set on top of the cabinet.

Taran Ael watched her movement with curiosity: “What is that?”

“This is a ‘witch’s potion’ we’ll use in a bit,” Lucretia said casually, clearly not intending to answer him directly. She moved on at once: “About the time when the Sun went out, and about the dream just now, there are things I want to ask. I know we already spoke briefly in the dreamscape, but dreams block parts of the subconscious. There may be things you didn’t notice then. Now I need you to recall everything again while fully awake.”

Hearing the seriousness in the Lady’s voice, Taran Ael’s expression quickly turned serious as well. The bearing of a scholar returned to him. “All right, ask whatever you wish. My head already feels much clearer now.”

“You observed the surface of Vision 001 while the Sun was out. This is the sketch you left,” Lucretia said without ceremony. She pulled out a crumpled sheet of paper and handed it to him. “Is this it?”

“Yes, I drew that.”

“I’ve already checked. The drawing itself doesn’t carry any mental corruption. But the content is disturbing. On the surface of that ‘sphere’, you drew these messy, branch?like lines. From my analysis, many of these lines seem to have been added near the end, in a rush, to cover the original, clearer pattern. Do you remember that?”

Taran Ael’s brows furrowed at once.

He took the paper from Lucretia and stared at the spherical image covered in chaotic lines. The more he looked, the more tightly his brows knitted, and his mind sank into thought and memory.

Lucretia's voice came again from across from him: "A very important question is this—do you truly remember all the details from the moment you finished observing the Sun's surface to the moment you fell asleep? From the looks of it, you're as puzzled by these tangled lines as I am…"

"I… am indeed a little confused," Taran Ael said slowly. "This really does look like obvious smearing, but I don't remember why I covered the earlier details… It seems…"

He suddenly stopped. After chewing over his words, he went on hesitantly: "Perhaps I saw something extremely terrible. Or a truth that should not be made public. I drew it without control. But just before I operated the express dispatch, I suddenly woke up to myself, so I hurried to cover it… Yet for some reason, I still wanted to send it out…"

Even though things were still somewhat muddled and there were clear breaks in his memory, Taran Ael's reason and logic as a seasoned scholar still took the lead. He analyzed what had happened to him, then his expression grew grave. "How many people have seen this paper so far?"

"A small number of senior scholars at Truth Academy," Lucretia said with a nod. "The original is still with me. They only saw the smeared version. I've already warned them. And the fact that you fell into deep sleep is a warning in itself, so you don't have to worry about anyone secretly studying this sketch and trying to restore what you saw. But the Boundless Sea is very large. We can't rule out the chance that some other 'brave soul' did something just as bold as you."

Taran Ael nodded thoughtfully. Then he heard the Witch continue: "About that dream—what else do you remember? How did you do the

dreamwalking? Did your mind ever sink down to its true ‘last layer’?”

“I only remember that when I woke up, I was already standing in that ‘forest’,” Taran Ael said, thinking back as he spoke. “Just like in some old books—an endless, dense forest, the place where the elves came from… My thoughts in that dream felt very slow. The voices I heard, the information I sensed, and my reactions to the outside world all seemed to pass through a thick barrier…”

He spoke while recalling, then suddenly frowned.

“But there was one very strange part. Not long after you appeared, my thoughts did sink for a moment, but not to the last layer of the dream. Instead, it was like a place between one ‘layer’ and another. Many chaotic lights and shadows tangled together there, as if several very different dreams were overlapping and projecting into each other. And in that chaotic region, there were many hazy figures gathered around me…”

“Many hazy figures?” Lucretia interrupted him at once. “Explain clearly. Were they illusions inside the dream, or ‘dreamers’ like you?”

“I don’t know. At that time my thoughts were almost frozen. I could only feel that they were there and could not clearly describe what they were. But one thing is certain… They were not illusions,” Taran Ael said, his face serious. “They truly existed. Even if they weren’t other dreamers, they were other ‘mental entities’ contained in that dream.”

“I see.” Lucretia nodded, her expression calm. She let out a small breath. “That really is… vital information.”

“I hope it can be of use,” Taran Ael said earnestly. Then he glanced down at the sketch in his hand. “Then about this drawing…”

“I now think it’s best not to let ordinary scholars come into contact with it. Whatever you ‘smeared out’ is clearly harmful to normal minds,” Lucretia

said, pulling the sketch out of his hand. “I’ll let Father take a look later. Maybe he’ll think of something.”

Taran Ael blinked, took a second to react, then nodded: “Oh, right. Captain Duncan certainly won’t be afraid of whatever’s hidden in this drawing. Then we’ll wait until he arrives. I’m in no hurry…”

“Ah, that’s the other thing I wanted to tell you,” Lucretia said, leisurely shifting her posture as she looked into Taran Ael’s eyes. “My Father has already arrived at Lightwind Harbor.”

Taran Ael’s eyes went wide, and his expression froze at once.

“Maybe because of the special influence of the Sun going out, the Vanished reached its destination in an instant,” Lucretia said with a small nod. “He should be very interested in speaking with you face to face, or inviting you to his ship. He cares a great deal about the Sun’s extinction.”

Taran Ael stayed dazed for a few more seconds. Then his eyes suddenly focused, as if he had sobered in an instant. He drew in a sharp breath and leaned backward—

Lucretia watched him without any change in her expression. She calmly picked up the potion bottle she had set on the low cabinet and handed it to Lunie: “Pour this into Mr. Taran Ael.”

Lunie gave a soft “oh” and took the potion to carry out her Mistress’s order. Lucretia watched the Grand Scholar being dosed and nodded in satisfaction.

“See? It came in handy.”

Today, the Sea Witch once again successfully stopped Master Taran Ael from dropping dead on her ship.

Chapter 532:

Heidi followed the staff member in a dark blue uniform toward another ward deeper inside the medical facility while listening to the explanation along the way:

“That patient woke up first and found you collapsed beside her bed. She ran into the corridor to call for help, and only then did we realize something had happened in the ward…

“Because of your earlier instructions, we first asked the Church guardians and the resident priest to inspect the area around the ward, but they did not find any sign of extraordinary power or corruption. Only you would not wake from your sleep… So we moved you to a ward a bit closer to the small cathedral…

“That elven young lady is still in the facility. Her mental state is good, but she does not seem to remember what happened in the dream, and she cannot explain how she suddenly fell into that sleep. We asked her to stay a little longer for now, in case you want to ask her something.

“Her family is here as well. If you need anything, you can ask…”

The staff member suddenly stopped. A trace of hesitation appeared on the face, and the staff member turned to look at Heidi: “I am sorry. I forgot that you also just woke from a long sleep. You should be resting now…”

“I do not need rest. I have slept long enough this time.” Heidi waved a hand. Her gaze kept drifting over the staff member’s face despite herself, but she quickly forced her expression and eyes back under control. Then

she asked, as if casually: “Before you came in, did anything strange happen in my room?”

“Something strange?” The staff member frowned and thought for a moment, then shook the head. “No. Did something happen?”

An uninvited guest had crossed a fissure in the timeline and intruded into the ward—then dropped a heap of cryptic, ominous words before leaving.

Heidi replayed what had just happened in her mind, but soon shook her head and said calmly, “No, I was just asking. I wanted to confirm whether anything unusual happened in my room while I was asleep.”

This “staff member” was only an ordinary person responsible for reception. The rambling, unsettling Ender, on the other hand, felt far too strange to Heidi. Out of caution, it was better not to let news of that “preacher” reach an ordinary person’s ears.

When she went back, she should report directly to the Cathedral, or to the central great Cathedral of the city-state.

Maybe she should also tell her father. And that… Captain Duncan?

All kinds of thoughts turned in Heidi’s mind. Some of them even made her feel a little chill. While her thoughts rose and fell like waves, she had already been led to the end of the corridor.

The staff member who had guided her finished a brief handover with the nurse at the door, then left quietly. Heidi took a deep breath in front of the ward, quickly straightened out her state and expression, then reached out and pushed the door open.

In the bright, tidy ward, the elven maiden who had been trapped in sleep earlier was now calmly half-reclining on the bed. She leaned against a pile of pillows and blankets, holding a book and reading intently. A plump,

kindly looking elven old lady sat on the edge of the bed, carefully peeling an apple.

When Heidi stepped into the room, the elven maiden immediately looked up. A bright smile bloomed on her face: “Ah! Miss Doctor! You are awake?”

“I came to see how you are doing.” Heidi smiled back as she walked over to the bed. She nodded politely to the kindly looking elven old lady. “Hello. May I ask, you are…?”

“She is my grandmother!” the elven maiden on the bed hurried to answer.

The old lady gave her granddaughter a helpless look, then turned to Heidi with a smile. “This child is a bit too familiar with everyone… Thank you very much for what you did for Flora, Miss Heidi.”

A faint trace of awkwardness appeared on Heidi’s face. “I feel like I did not help much. Even this ‘doctor’ fell into sleep.”

“But I heard from the staff here that you fell asleep because you tried to wake Flora from her nightmare,” the old lady said. She passed the freshly peeled apple to Heidi, and her warm, sincere attitude did not sound like empty politeness at all. “And Flora also said she felt someone protecting her in her sleep—when danger came close, a series of gunshots drove away her fear.”

A series of gunshots? Danger approaching?

Was that the Annihilator who tried to get close to the bed through the “suggestion gateway” she had opened, during the backlash of the dream?

A guess flashed through Heidi’s mind. She thanked the old lady for the apple, then sat down on the chair beside the bed. She looked seriously at the elven girl named Flora. “Your name is Flora, right? Do you remember how you fell asleep?”

“I remember… I was reading at home.” Flora frowned as she thought. “Before that, the Sun went out. Grandmother said the streets were dangerous and told me to stay in my room. Later the Sun lit up again, and I got really bored, so I picked up a book to read—after all, the Sun was shining again. But I don’t know why. After reading for only a little while, I suddenly felt very sleepy and then fell asleep…”

“Reading a book?”

Heidi muttered under her breath. Her eyes swept over the book that Flora had been holding a moment ago. On the pale violet cover, an ornate string of letters caught her eye—*The Crystal Garden of the Dreamless Prince*.

“In my opinion, it is all because she keeps reading this kind of nonsense,” the plump elven madam grumbled at the side. “Her head is full of unreliable fantasies. If she keeps reading this stuff, she will be corrupted sooner or later. The gods will never bless a romance between two men…”

Flora immediately protested from the side. “Not two—several!”

Heidi shook her head to the old lady. “Do not worry. It was not the content of this book that caused this.”

As soon as she finished speaking, Flora looked pleasantly surprised. “Doctor Sis, you read this too?!”

Heidi: “…”

Drawing on many years of finely honed professional skill, Miss Psychiatrist ignored the very different expressions that flashed across Flora’s and her grandmother’s faces. She instead turned a serious gaze on the elven maiden. “Putting that aside, during the time when the Sun went out, you did not try to look at its surface or glance up at the sky, did you?”

“Of course not. Who would dare?” Flora stuck out her tongue. “What sane person would go staring around when the Sun is extinguished?”

Heidi kept a straight face and asked another question: “Do you remember what happened while you were asleep? Even a little impression is fine—aside from the ‘gunshots’. I know about that part.”

“…Aside from those gunshots, there really is only a little bit I remember,” Flora said. She thought hard and spoke with some uncertainty. “I just remember lying in the dark. I felt groggy and could not see anything around me, and I could not really hear anything either. In that darkness, there were many, many shadows, like other people, all standing around me…”

Heidi’s expression immediately grew solemn. “Many, many shadows?”

…

In the depths of the Boundless Sea, in a city-state far from Pland and Lightwind Harbor, a figure wrapped in a thick black coat slipped in a hurry into a narrow alley.

The figure moved quickly, but the steps were slightly unsteady, as if shaken by panic. He avoided any possible prying eyes at the mouth of the alley and slipped through one side path after another. After wandering through the maze-like back lanes long enough to make anyone lose their way, he finally darted into a small house.

dusk was drawing near. The last glow of the Sun was quietly fading from the city. The gas lamps on the streets had not yet been lit. The dimness arrived early, sinking slowly over one house after another.

The soft hiss of a match being struck sounded. An oil lamp in the house was lit.

The man tossed his thick black coat over the arm of the sofa, then walked to the cabinet, took out a bottle of spirits, and poured himself a full glass. He carried it back to the sofa, sat down, and drained half the glass in one gulp.

Only then, wrapped in the faint sense of safety brought by the oil lamp's light, did he let out a long breath.

The strong liquor burned his tongue and his nerves, easing that horror that clung to him like bone-deep frost. He felt courage and life slowly returning to his body, and his cold hands and feet grew warm again.

A faint clinking of chains sounded behind him. A black chain slowly emerged out of thin air. One end of the chain was fastened to his body. The other end bound a jellyfish-like thing that floated in midair, as if made of gathered smoke and dust.

The dull-witted demon revealed its form, pulsing and squirming mindlessly in the air as it sent waves of restless unease toward the man.

"I know, I know. We almost got into big trouble," the man muttered irritably. He knew the Abyssal demons had no hearts and could not understand human language, but after many years living under a symbiotic pact with the demon, he had unconsciously gotten used to talking to it, as if this dangerous cloud of smoke were truly a family member or a friend he could trust. "Who could have guessed that captain cursed by the curse would suddenly appear… damn it, what does any of this have to do with him…"

He put down his glass, leaned back on the sofa, and lifted his head, staring at the ceiling with unfocused eyes. His tone was full of resentment.

"Those Sun remnants who are as stupid as bricks were useless. They could not even handle that 'witch'… Tch. The believers at the bottom are all idiots. Even those called 'envoys' are just brainless scraps. The so-called Sun spawn are nothing but puppets that cannot think… Among those Sun believers, from top to bottom you can hardly find a single one whose mind is whole. I was almost killed because of them…"

He grumbled as he spoke, then picked up his glass again and gulped twice more. Feeling his heartbeat slowly easing, he turned his head to glance at his demon bound by the symbiotic pact.

“Calm down. We are safe now. We will find another chance. If those chattering preachers were right, more and more elves will soon be affected by the ‘Primordial Defect’. We will have other chances to slip into that dream…”

He suddenly fell silent.

The Smokewisp Jellyfish was pulsing and twisting more and more violently in the air, sending increasingly frantic signals to its symbiotic pact-bearer. The man seemed to sense something at last—his dull spiritual intuition finally began to raise an alarm. As rising waves of fear washed over him, his perception finally broke through the self-protection of his subconscious and began to notice… that gaze, so close at hand.

He swallowed hard and slowly lowered his eyes.

He looked at the glass in his hand.

The remaining liquor rippled slightly in the cup, reflecting the wavering light of the oil lamp. In that faintly eerie greenish firelight, a gloomy and austere face appeared in the reflection, calmly fixing him with a divine gaze.

“Go on,” he heard a hazy voice echo in his mind, as if it were his own thoughts speaking. “I like people who are used to talking to themselves.”

Chapter 533:

Faced with this incomprehensible and terrifying sight, the man froze for one or two seconds. Then he suddenly let out a shout, flung the glass away in panic, and dove to the side.

The glass hit the floor and shattered at once. The remaining liquor splashed across the floor like blood. On the surface of every droplet, tiny sparks and that same gloomy, austere face seemed to flicker for an instant. The man staggered back, almost tripping over the sofa beside him. He only managed to stay on his feet by grabbing the wall for support.

Panting hard, he stared wide-eyed at the broken glass and spilled liquor on the floor. His heart pounded as if it would explode. The Smokewisp Jellyfish bound to him under the symbiotic pact drifted blindly nearby, then gradually shrank into a strange, tight ball.

The shattered glass and spilled liquor no longer held that terrifying reflection. What had just happened seemed like nothing but a horrific hallucination. The man tried to steady his breathing, hoping that taking in more fresh air would calm him down. A faint, shaky thought began to rise from his heart. Maybe it really was an illusion. Maybe he really was just too nervous…

“It is all illusions, all illusions… It is mental instability after exposure to Subspace…” he muttered quickly, talking to himself as he laid down layer after layer of mental suggestion. At the same time he drew power from the Abyssal demon of his symbiotic pact to build spiritual defenses. “Stop associating, stop remembering, avoid connections, avoid connections…

Holy Master, grant me Your shelter. Let me live forever in the Abyssal Deep. Holy Master, grant…”

“I appreciate your optimistic spirit,” a voice sounded in his ear, “but blind optimism does not solve anything. Relax. I only want to learn a few things from you.”

The man broke off his prayer at once. The voice that reached his ears was like a dreadful whisper from Subspace itself, clutching his mind with an almost physical grip. In stiff, jerky movements, he turned his neck toward the source of the sound—and saw it on the glass of the cabinet. In the glass, ghost-green flame burned quietly. Within the flames was reflected that ghost from Subspace.

“Get out!”

A surge of courage came from nowhere. The Annihilator suddenly grew vicious. He flung out his hand, drawing on the strength of the Smokewisp Jellyfish, and hurled a murky, corrosive ball of energy at the cabinet. With a thunderous bang, the entire cabinet exploded into splinters. Glass shards flew through the room.

But before the shards even hit the ground, that terrifying figure appeared again—this time on a mirror in the corner of the room. “Have you vented enough? If you have, let us talk calmly.”

At last, the cultist found the pattern—mirrors.

That Subspace ghost could invade this place through mirrors!

The next second, the man smashed the mirror in the corner without hesitation. Then he went berserk, destroying every glass ornament on the nearby shelves and every object within sight that could reflect an image!

Sharp crashes rang out over and over as glass shattered across the room. Whatever he could smash, he smashed. Whatever he could not smash, he

covered with newspapers, clothes, or anything else he could grab. Fear turned into anger, and anger turned into a false courage. Fueled by that "courage," the cultist moved at frantic speed, sealing off and destroying every medium in the room that might let the Subspace ghost "descend." All the while, ghost-green flames flickered from one reflective surface to another, and that grim figure in the mirrors almost never stopped harassing him.

New mirrors kept appearing. New voices kept speaking. New faces kept surfacing within his field of view, gazing at him with gloomy divine eyes.

He did not know how long this ghastly torment continued, but at last it began to fade.

The man had almost destroyed or covered every object in the room that could reflect anything. He had drawn thick curtains over all the windows. As he hurled the last glass vase into the trash, the building fell silent again.

Darkness had settled outside. Inside the room, only the glow of the oil lamp flickered faintly. At some point, the terrifying ghost-green tint had faded from the flame. Standing amid the wreckage, the cultist gulped for air as he watched the dimness and quiet pressing in around him.

It really seemed that the ghost would not appear again.

Even the Smokewisp Jellyfish bound to him under the symbiotic pact had quieted. It now looked withered. The smoke curling from its body was thin and dim, as if the recent struggle had consumed so much of its power that it could hardly maintain a form in the Mortal Realm.

The man stood in the darkness for a long time, as if weighing something with great care. Only after a long while did he slowly let out a breath, reach for the black coat on the sofa, and quickly pull it on.

The noise in the room just now had been loud. It might already have attracted the neighbors' attention. In a remote neighborhood like this, the constables were always slow to respond, but as long as someone filed a report, trouble might still come knocking.

What was more, this room had already been marked by that Subspace ghost. It was no longer safe. Smashing and covering the mirrors only blocked the channels through which the ghost could descend, but could never truly remove its influence.

Right now, the ghost was only temporarily kept out of the Mortal Realm. Before the constables reacted and before the ghost found a new way to intrude, the only right choice was to leave as fast as possible.

The man quickly laid out his next steps in his mind. He buttoned his coat, hid away the demon of his symbiotic pact, and strode toward the door.

But just before leaving the room, he stopped again. His eyes fell on the pile of junk in the center of the room, covered with newspapers and torn rags.

He thought for a moment, then flung out a hand and hurled a dark ball of energy—the papers and cloth flew away, revealing a heap of shattered mirrors and glass scattered over the floor, glinting with cold, ominous light in the gloom.

"It will be better if someone reports this."

The man smiled in satisfaction, then did not dare look at those shards any longer. He turned, opened the door, and slipped out into the veil of night.

He moved cautiously through the streets and alleys, using the shadows of the buildings as cover and sometimes hiding his form with spells. He quickly left the area that was no longer safe and, following the familiar routes in his memory, ran toward the Lower City.

Curfew had already begun. Guardians were on the streets. Anyone wandering outside might be stopped and questioned. But for a cultist who had been active in this city-state for many years and was long used to life under the veil of night, this was not much of a problem.

As long as he did not cause too much noise, the “blind spots” right under the noses of the Church’s guardians were everywhere.

Hidden in the darkness, the figure slipped through the checkpoint between districts, then entered the more tangled, ancient alleys of the Lower City. After winding through countless turns and side streets, he finally stopped in front of an old, ordinary-looking house.

The man carefully checked his surroundings, making sure there was no sign of that eerie ghost-green fire in his vision and no suspicious noise in his mind. Only then did he let out a small breath and step forward to knock on the door in a set pattern.

He waited patiently until footsteps approached on the other side. A lowered voice sounded from behind the door:

“It is late. Whatever it is, talk about it tomorrow.”

“The night is very deep. My traveling companion and I just want to come in and rest our feet—we have brought some interesting stories from afar.”

Silence fell behind the door. After roughly ten seconds, a soft click sounded as the lock turned. The door opened quietly in the dark, and a thin, small figure appeared in the doorway under the dim light.

“Come in. Do not make too much noise.”

The man nodded, slipped quickly inside, and closed the door behind him. Only when he heard the soft click of the lock settling back into place did he finally relax a little, a look of relief crossing his face like someone who had barely escaped with his life.

“Why did you come at this hour?” the thin figure asked, still watching the “brother” who had just entered with caution. Although his identity had already been confirmed, his behavior did not fit “protocol,” which put the thin man on edge. “We did not receive any advance word from you.”

“Something sudden happened,” the man in the black coat said, shaking his head and lowering his voice. “My operation failed. An unexpected Higher Being intervened, and now He has His eyes on me—but do not worry, I have temporarily blocked His channels into the Mortal Realm. Right now the urgent thing is to report this upward…”

The small-bodied cultist’s expression turned solemn at once. He quickly cut him off and stopped him from saying more. Then he picked up an oil lamp from the nearby table and walked toward the corner as he spoke softly: “Come with me. We will go underground. Do not speak of our actions under the Four Gods’ gaze.”

“All right.”

The small cultist opened a hidden door in the corner. The two figures, one after the other, slipped into a sloping passage that led down.

Soon, they reached the gathering place beneath the building.

Calling it a gathering place was generous. It was really just a secret basement that had been dug out in secret. In the not-so-large room, several chairs stood around a round table. A few oil lamps burned upon it, alongside a messy spread of tools and materials used for rituals and heretical worship.

At the far end of the room stood a dark statue. It looked like an eerie, twisted “tree.” Its black trunk branched into dizzying, thorn-like limbs that radiated a faint, unsettling presence.

The man in the black coat walked down the steps and saw that several figures were already gathered here. They were the “brothers” who had

followed procedure and hurried underground the moment he knocked on the door.

His gaze swept over these “brothers,” and they raised their heads in turn, examining this Visitor who had come after nightfall.

After a few heartbeats, the tight air in the room eased a little. The man in the black coat let out a breath, walked up to the round table, and sat down on an empty chair.

Closest to him sat a man with dry, yellowish hair and a sickly, gloomy face. He looked up at the newcomer, stared for a moment in silence, then suddenly asked, “You ran into trouble?”

“I could not break through that ‘dream’. The Enders must have given us bad information—damn it, I should have known. No one is worth trusting except the Holy Master’s followers…”

“Slow down. Calm yourself first,” the sickly-faced man said, forcing out a small smile as he picked up a glass of water from nearby and slid it over. “Drink some water.”

The man in the black coat took the glass and exhaled. “Thanks, Duncan.”

…

“Reynard! Please, be a decent person!”

“Eh? A person? But I am a fox spirit.”

“And also, please call me Adoptive Father.”)

Chapter 534: The Time for Prayer

The man finally began to calm down.

He had escaped that building corrupted by the Subspace Shadows, escaped those terrible mirrors and burning flames, and come to the gathering hall watched over by the Holy Lord's gaze and divine blessing. Now trusted comrades were all around him. The flickering lights gave off a soothing strength. The concern and encouragement of like-minded believers slowly washed away his panic and tension.

It seemed that nothing terrible was going to happen.

So the man in the thick black coat let out a long breath. Then he picked up the cup of water Duncan had handed him, ready to wet the throat that had gone dry from running all the way here.

But as soon as he lifted the cup and saw the rippling surface of the water inside, he felt a stab of discomfort. A faint unease rose up from his heart, and he set the cup back down.

Clearly this was a "side effect" of the awful incident earlier. He felt that for at least the next few hours he had better not touch any drink in a cup again. If it really could not be helped, he would just find a straw later.

"So what exactly happened?" the cultist with straw-yellow hair and a grim face, the one who had just handed him the cup, asked with concern. "What kind of trouble did you run into?"

Around the round table, the other Annihilators also turned their eyes this way. Curiosity and seriousness showed on every face.

“That dream… the Nameless One’s dream the Ender mentioned. Inside it there was a maze of structures, and a barrier protected it,” the man in the black coat said with a sigh, still shaken. “The entrance did not ‘appear on its own.’ I do not know how it went for the other comrades who tried to enter. On my side, I was blocked out. Even the remnants of the Sun were kept outside. But that was not the worst part. The worst was…”

The man suddenly stopped. He glanced in confusion at the “comrade” beside him, and his brows drew together: “Duncan, are you alright? You look terrible…”

“Me? I feel fine,” the “Annihilator” with the dry yellow hair said with a laugh. His laugh sounded a little hoarse. “You are too nervous.”

“You really are too nervous. Duncan’s face has always looked this sickly,” another person at the table said, shaking his head. “Go on. What was the worst part? Ordinary trouble would not make you react like this.”

“…Duncan Abnomar, the ghost of the curse who returned from the Subspace,” the man in black said, still full of fear. “He stepped into that Nameless One’s dream.”

The hall fell silent at once. It was as if an unseen freezing wind blew through, making the air in the basement suddenly thick and still.

In that sudden, suffocating silence, the man in black felt a heavy pressure. But he forced himself to calm down and went on: “First I ran into a very troublesome psychiatrist. That psychiatrist broke through the ‘psychology chamber’ I set up. Then, in the open area of the Nameless One’s dream, I met the even more troublesome sea witch. Things were not too bad yet at

that point. The remnants of the Sun held back the witch's movements. But then, Duncan Abnomar suddenly appeared…

"That ghost ruined everything. Those remnants of the Sun and their 'blood kin' were no match for him at all. The information from outside was wrong. Duncan Abnomar and the sea witch were not enemies at all. They talked right in front of me, and their relationship was much friendlier than people guessed.

"Do you remember the reports from Frostholm? I even suspect the Vanished fleet never really disbanded. The Radiant Star and the Sea Mist have been carrying out that ghost's orders in secret the whole time. And this time… I just happened to uncover their secret. That ghost and his two children must also be paying attention to the matter of the Nameless One's dream…"

He spoke quickly. His mind had never felt so active. The terrifying experience he had just gone through began to reorder itself in his head, linking up with all kinds of secret information that had been spreading through different channels lately. In the end it formed a very convincing chain of logic, at least convincing to himself. As he laid it out, he felt he had finally sorted his messy thoughts and understood everything.

But then a gaze from across the round table, heavy as something solid, suddenly fell on him and cut him off.

"Wait," the owner of that gaze said. He was an old man with graying hair and an air of authority. His eyes were sharp, and his deep voice carried the sternness of a leader. "Are you saying you ran into those Subspace Shadows in the Nameless One's dream, and that it has already set its eyes on you?"

"Y-yes," the man in black said, suddenly tense. Under the Envoy's gaze he felt fear by instinct, but he still forced himself to answer. "It tracked me into the Mortal Realm and tried to invade my hiding place through mirrors. But

I found the pattern of how it entered the Mortal Realm and blocked those ‘passages’…”

He spoke quickly, and finally, under the Envoy’s gaze, he began to feel that coldness. His dull, numb mind reacted at last. He noticed it at last—the constant noise that had been buzzing in his head, and the formless things squirming and twitching at the edge of his vision.

He slowly stood up. The muscles all over his body trembled. He accidentally brushed against the “comrade” sitting closest to him. That person raised his head and gave him a friendly smile, yet deep inside that smile there was a strange taste he could not name.

The man in black felt a sudden tightness in his chest. He spoke, hesitant and nervous: “Duncan, you… why does your face look even worse than before…”

The “Annihilator” with the dry yellow hair and sickly, sinister face sighed and shook his head with a hint of regret.

“Annihilators… In a way, your strange symbiotic pact ecosystem gives you a natural resistance to me,” he said calmly. “The Abyssal demons you rely on have sharp senses but not enough mind to weigh gains and losses. So in a very short time, these demons collapse. Right after that, the ‘vessels’ transformed out of your bodies break down as well. Even in the best case, they only last a little more than ten minutes…”

The “Annihilator” called “Duncan” spoke slowly. As he talked, a faint crackling sound came from all over his body. Behind him, a dim dark Shadow bound in chains seemed to struggle as it faded away. His body quickly filled with black cracks and began to crumble and fall apart bit by bit.

Duncan slowly spread his hands. The Abyssal demons that had formed a symbiotic pact with this body were already dead. The body itself slowly turned to ash as well.

“But the good news is, even in such a short time, I still heard quite a lot of useful things.”

That body crumbled away completely. Under the flickering yellow light, countless black ashes fell in silence.

The man in black stared in horror. In those few short seconds, he could not even tell whether fear, regret, or anger came first in his heart. Then he suddenly came to his senses. He looked up at the Envoy sitting across the table and cried: “I am guilty—”

“You are guilty.”

The gray-haired Envoy spoke without any expression. He raised his hand and pointed forward. In the darkness, a silent, shapeless shadow suddenly appeared and then vanished again in the hall. In that brief instant, the “guilty” man in black lowered his head, and his body slumped in the chair.

A few seconds later, the body burst into flame. Black fire swallowed his flesh in an instant, filling the air with a sickening smell.

The cultists in the hall watched in silence. No one made a sound. Only when the heap of burning black ash finally collapsed did a tall figure hesitantly break the silence: “Envoy, we…”

The man known as the Envoy did not answer. The pale-haired cult leader only swept a calm look over everyone in the room. Then he rose without expression, went to close the main entrance of the hall, and locked the hidden door used for emergency escape. After that, he murmured a benediction in front of both doors. Black thorns grew quickly under his prayer and sealed the doors in an instant.

The small cultist who had led the Visitor here earlier leaped to his feet when he saw this: “Envoy! What are you…?”

“Duncan was one of our earliest members,” the cult leader said calmly. His eyes moved over the two piles of black ash by the round table. “When do you think he was transformed?”

The Annihilators in the room looked at one another. One by one, they finally understood, and horror spread over their faces.

“He is among us,” the Envoy said as he came back to the round table. He looked at the believers gathered there and spoke slowly. “Any moment, any person, any face… He has already come in.”

“What should we do?” someone at the table asked.

“From now on, do not discuss our Lord’s secrets, and do not share information about the Cult. In our mortal bodies, we have no way to fight the Subspace Shadows. But the Lord will still witness our courage and toughness. We will no longer reveal any information to that ghost, no matter what terror or temptation He uses here…”

The Envoy spoke slowly. Then he spread his hands and went on in a solemn preaching tone:

“I will find a way to send out what we know about that Subspace ghost, including His way of invasion and His power to tempt. At the same time, I will stay here with you. As you can see, I have already sealed every passage out of this place.

“Believers, the time has come to prove your loyalty to the Lord. Let us pray. In the realm deep within the Abyssal Deep, the Lord’s divine blessing will make our souls live forever. All the suffering of today will be repaid in that eternal realm.

“Now, begin the prayer.”

Chapter 535: Enthusiastically Maintaining Public Order

So the Annihilators began their prayer.

They prayed under the dim light of the oil lamps, in the deathly still air, in that deep, cold hall, under the gaze of the Abyssal Lord.

A member who had acted rashly under Mental Derangement had brought that unshakable Shadow into this hall. From now on, anyone who left the hall might carry that Shadow to other comrades, just like what had already happened. So they would not leave here again. Under the Envoy's witness and encouragement, these devout and fanatical cultists chose a quiet and loyal sacrifice.

They had made up their minds to carry the secrets they knew to the Lord's realm and never again leak a single bit to that ghost.

At least, that was the decision they made now. A moment of courage was always easy.

The cultists prayed in silence, calling again and again for the divine blessing of the Abyssal Lord in the secret room. The Envoy sat quietly at the round table. His calm gaze rested on every face in the room, taking in their firmness, nerves, bravery, fear, and wavering.

Time passed, and no one knew how long. The flame on the oil lamp on the table flickered, dimming and brightening. During one sudden flare of the light, someone seemed to hear a faint voice:

“…I will give you one chance.”

Someone lifted his head in fear, searching for the source of the voice. Someone else squeezed his eyes shut, afraid he would really see something. But the voice had already faded into the air, as if it had never been there.

“Keep praying,” the Envoy said softly. His words seemed to carry a strange persuasive power. “That ghost can do nothing. Aside from death, He has no way left to threaten us. And death itself is the quickest road to the Lord’s realm.”

In the past, the Envoy’s words always gave people courage and quickly steadied even the most uneasy followers. Yet this time, for some reason, every word he spoke only made people feel a colder chill of coming horror.

Growing unease spread through the hall. Fear crept toward the edge of reason. Doubt slowly grew in the silence. Not everyone here was one of the most devout Saints. And for those who were less devout, this was the time for their reason to break.

At last, one believer screamed. It was the smallest one. He seemed to have suddenly seen something terrible. He leaped from his chair and shouted: “I will talk! I will talk! I know what is going on!”

The Envoy shot to his feet and shouted in anger and alarm: “Hold him down!”

Several figures around the round table rushed over at once. They grabbed the small figure roughly and angrily, pinned him hard onto the table, and tried to cover his mouth to keep him from spilling the Lord’s secrets. But the small cultist burst out with shocking strength. He struggled wildly. Black chains appeared around him. Terrible bone spurs and hardened growths formed on his limbs, almost letting him break free from his comrades’ hold, as he kept shouting:

“The Enders gave us the information! They said the Nameless One’s dream hides the Truth from the creation of the world and holds the Lord’s first Blueprint…

“The dreams of the elves can lead to the Nameless One’s dream! That race itself is the vessel and passage for dreams, because they already had flaws at the Blueprint stage…

“The followers of the Black Sun are also moving, but they are looking for something else. I do not even know what they are searching for!

“The Enders said the time is near, but this is all I know… This is all I know, Mr. Duncan. Only the Prophets and the Saints know more, and those Enders, they know… I really only know these things!”

The small cultist struggled and shouted as fast as he could. In his huge fear, he found another kind of courage, the courage to betray his faith. But right after that, he forced his head up again, tears and snot running down his face, and looked toward the Envoy not far away. After that brief courage came new fear: “I am sorry, I just want to live, I want to live…”

Then he screamed again: “Mr. Duncan! Please protect me! Do not let the Envoy kill me! I kept my promise, you said you would give me a chance! You said… you would…”

The heavy weight pressing on his shoulders eased. The small cultist screamed in terror halfway through his words, then finally, belatedly, sensed the change in the air and slowly fell silent.

All along, only his own screams echoed in the hall. His “comrades” held him down, but not one of them truly tried to stop him from shouting. The Envoy watched him with a steady gaze and never lifted a hand.

He stared, eyes wide, as the Envoy slowly placed both hands on the table and gave him a gentle smile: “See? Saying it was not that hard.”

Around the round table, the cultists who had been holding him down stepped back one after another.

His “comrades” stood around him, watching him. Their faces showed stiff but gentle smiles. Then they began to clap for him, one after another.

The small cultist stared, eyes wide. He looked in terror at everyone in the hall. At last his lips trembled as he spoke: “Envoy… Lord Duncan, and Duncan, Duncan, you all are…”

A series of chilling howls and roars rang out. One after another, Abyssal demons appeared in the hall. Some were already breaking apart. Some were pulling at chains and struggling to flee the Mortal Realm. As these symbiotic pact demons broke down or escaped, every figure in the small cultist’s eyes, including the Envoy, suddenly burst into flame.

Before the last burning figure collapsed, it walked up to the small cultist, smiled, and patted him on the shoulder: “You too.”

The hall fell silent.

The small figure stood quietly among the countless piles of black ash. After a few seconds, he suddenly blinked. Then he hurried back to the round table, grabbed pen and paper from the top, and quickly wrote a full page.

Then he snatched up the sheet of paper and walked to the basement’s exit. The “thorns” the Envoy had summoned still sealed the door tight. Dark, wicked power flowed through the tangled thorns.

But in a single instant, the thorny growth burst into flame. Pale green spirit form fire turned it to ash, and the door behind the thorns swung open with a push.

Duncan strode through the basement door while the embers had not yet died, passed through the run-down buildings on the surface, and then his figure rose into the air amid the flames…

A patrolling Guardian stared in shock as a ball of eerie green flame fell onto the street in front of him. He had just raised his weapon on instinct when a staggering figure, seemingly falling apart bit by bit, stepped out of the green fire.

The small, unstable, and very suspicious figure walked toward him quickly, a bright smile on his face: “Hello, I would like to report heretic activity.”

The Guardian, who had been about to blow his whistle and attack with his sword at the same time, froze.

He had served the Church for many years, but this was the first time he had met this kind of… informant. In his confusion he blurted out: “Report?”

“Yes. It is in the basement of the house at the very end of that alley ahead, the one with the blue sloped roof. This is a denunciation letter. It has the basic details of their gatherings. At the end there is an anonymous bank account. Please transfer the Whistleblower Bounty straight into that account. Thank you.”

The Guardian stared blankly at this suspicious and strange fellow and listened to his stream of words. His mind was a mess. At last he could not help lifting a hand to point at the other’s face, which was constantly crumbling into ash: “Mister, you do not look very well…”

“I know. I am keeping it together as best I can, but it looks like I am still not doing it quite right. It is only fifteen minutes more stable than usual. Do not worry. Just do not forget to send the money…”

The young Guardian took the denunciation letter almost without thinking. Before the other man completely fell apart, he finally remembered to ask a question: “Mister, what is your name?”

“Just a helpful heretic…”

…

Aboard the Vanished, in the captain's cabin, Duncan came back to himself and let out a long breath.

His main consciousness had returned to the ship.

The Goathead at the edge of the chart table reacted at once and turned his head this way: "Ah, great Captain, it looks like you gained quite a lot?"

"I got useful information out of a group of cultists at a secret gathering," Duncan said with a sigh. He raised his hand and rubbed his brow hard. "Sadly, the time was too short. I did not have time to find out which city-state that was or whether there are other gathering points nearby. But it is not a big problem. I think we will be dealing with them again soon…"

On the wall not far away, the surface of an ancient-style Oval Scrying Mirror rippled with layers of shadows. Agatha's figure appeared in the mirror and looked at Duncan with curiosity: "Are you alright? You look a bit tired?"

"I was just trying a newer way to control an avatar form. I am not quite used to it yet," Duncan said, waving his hand. "Looks like splitting your mind is not something you can just try for fun. Maybe I should ask Heidi for advice when I get the chance… How can she split into dozens at once without getting confused?"

Agatha: "…?"

But Duncan did not stay on that topic. He soon frowned slightly and began to recall and sort out the information he had just gotten from "far away."

He had first thought it was only a normal Dream Invasion, just a strange nightmare. He had thought the appearance of those cultists was only an accident. He had not expected that behind it, shadows far beyond anyone's imagination would suddenly show themselves.

“The Nameless One’s dream…” Duncan lifted his head in thought and looked at Agatha in the mirror and at Goathead on the table. “Have you heard this term before?”

Chapter 536:

“Nameless One’s Dream?”

When they heard the unfamiliar term the captain suddenly tossed out, Agatha and Goathead looked at each other in surprise.

“Where did you hear that term?” After thinking for a moment, Agatha asked, “Is it part of the ‘intel’ you just got?”

“The Annihilators used it to refer to the ‘dream’ Heidi and Lucretia were trapped in before,” Duncan nodded slowly. “The first source of the intel was probably the Enders. After that, the Annihilators and the Sun Church cultists answered some kind of ‘call’ from those Preachers.

“If the intel is correct, this so?called ‘Nameless One’s Dream’ is something like a Vision. It spreads on a huge scale over many different dreams. And elves… under certain conditions, they seem to become a ‘passage’ into the Nameless One’s Dream.”

He paused for a moment, then went on: “Those cultists all seemed to have their own goals in the depths of the Nameless One’s Dream. The purpose of the Sun Church is still unclear, but the target of the Cult of Annihilation seems to be a so?called ‘original blueprint’.”

Agatha’s expression grew visibly more serious. “I truly have never heard of anything like this ‘Nameless One’s Dream’. But in theory, a Vision on that scale… shouldn’t have stayed unknown for so many years. You just said elves would become a ‘passage’ under certain conditions?”

Duncan nodded slightly. “According to those Annihilators, elves have some kind of ‘defect at the blueprint stage’. Because of this, their minds form a link with the Nameless One’s Dream. It should tie back again to that whole creation theory of the Abyssal Lord, but we don’t have enough intel.”

“…I’m sorry, Captain. It seems we can’t give you any useful answers,” Agatha thought seriously for a while, then finally shook her head with a hint of apology. “But since this points straight at the race of ‘elves’, we can at least start investigating here in Lightwind Harbor. This is a city?state of the elves—and an elf here just recently fell into that dream.”

Duncan gave a soft grunt of agreement. He shifted his posture, leaned back in his chair, and tapped lightly on the armrest with his fingers. His gaze fell on the enchanted sea chart, where the fog was slowly clearing. “It is necessary to have a good talk with Master Taran Ael… Let’s go see the Radiant Star. And I should pay Lucretia a visit too.”

…

Outside Lightwind Harbor, in a stretch of open sea near the glowing fallen relic, the Radiant Star was slowly circling. sunlight spread over the surface of the water, making the ship look as if it were gliding over broken gold sand.

A gentle sea breeze blew against them. It carried the southern seas’ unique warmth—yet Master Taran Ael kept feeling a bit cold as he stood on the deck. He pulled his coat tighter against the wind, turned to look at the “sea witch” standing on a mast behind him, and shouted: “Are we just going to wait here?”

Lucretia lowered her head and glanced at the Grand Scholar on the deck. Her voice was not loud, but it carried clearly and directly into Taran Ael’s ears: “We are going to wait here.”

“Can I go back?” Taran Ael shouted again. “For the touching reunion of father and daughter, it feels a bit wrong to have an outsider standing around!”

Lucretia’s expression stayed blank. “Father said he wants to talk to you.”

Taran Ael raised both hands with a troubled face. “Then could you come down and stay with me? I… I’m a little nervous!”

Lucretia looked down at him from on high and gave him a quick once?over. “You are an adult, and a Grand Scholar with great prestige. You should learn to handle your own stress.”

“…Lady Lucretia, don’t tell me you’re nervous too?!”

“Why would I be nervous over something like this? That’s my…”

The voice from the mast suddenly stopped. Taran Ael froze for a second. He was about to ask what happened when a strong sense of dread struck him and cut off his words.

It was a warning from his Spiritual Insight, a sudden jolt of intuition. It was the instinctive tension of a “scholar” who had spent years dealing with dangerous items and hidden knowledge, the reaction he had when Truth drew near. In that instant, a layer of cold sweat broke out on Taran Ael’s skin. Right after that, he heard a low, deep sound, like the breathing of a giant beast, rumbling in his ears.

In the next second, thick fog and terrible light filled his vision.

Right beside the Radiant Star, at arm’s length, fog rose on the sea, appearing in an instant like a towering wall. The twisted light and shadow caused by the Spirit Realm flipping into place seemed about to pour out of that fog. Huge shadows rose up from the Spirit Realm and descended from the fog—

Just as in many dreadful legends of the sea, it came wrapped in darkness and chaos, burning with flames like Doomsday. It was as if a nightmare had suddenly grown a body in the Mortal Realm, like an unavoidable fate crashing straight down on them. Within just a few breaths, the towering bow of the Vanished crashed into the Mortal Realm.

Taran Ael stood frozen on the deck like a carved statue. He heard a “thump” from somewhere nearby, but he didn’t even have the courage to turn his head and look. Several more seconds passed before he finally remembered to breathe again, and he became aware of his heart pounding in his chest. The potion Lady Lucretia had forced him to drink earlier was still working, protecting his weak organs and letting them survive the shock.

Only then did the Grand Scholar slowly come back to himself. He got his voice back, and he quickly turned to look at where the “witch” had been standing before. “Lady Lucretia! Your father…”

There was no trace of the witch on the mast.

Taran Ael blinked, then instinctively looked around and shouted loudly: “Lady Lucretia! Lu—”

“Stop shouting. I’m right here.”

A cold voice with a hint of warning came from very close by, cutting off the scholar’s yelling. Taran Ael turned his head at once and saw Lucretia already standing on the deck. No one knew when she had come down. She stood beside him with a calm face, one hand raised in an elegant gesture to her forehead as her divine gaze rested on the bow of the Vanished.

“Ah, where did you go just now? I turned around and you…”

“Be quiet,” Lucretia snapped, her attitude unfriendly as she cut off the Grand Scholar. “Father doesn’t like people yelling during a meeting.”

Taran Ael shut his mouth at once. His whole body went tense as he stared at the huge ship burning with ghostly flames. Almost at the same time, he saw a flame appear out of thin air on the deck of the Radiant Star.

The flame rose quickly, swirling upward into a spinning doorway. In the next moment, a tall figure stepped out from within it.

Considering that this was his first visit to the Radiant Star, and in order to avoid unnecessary confusion on deck, Duncan had chosen to come alone.

Now, he finally set foot on this ship—one of the last two surviving escorts of the lost Hometown Fleet, the Radiant Star.

He also finally met Lucretia in the Mortal Realm—the “daughter” of Duncan Abnomar.

The “sea witch” wore a black dress with an adventurer’s style. She hesitated and walked a few steps toward him, but stopped again a few meters away. She kept her eyes on him, but her expression was complicated and stiff. She did her best to hide it, yet her nervousness and uncertainty could not be hidden at all.

Duncan could not help but recall what Tyrian had told him before they left Frostholm:

“Lucy gives outsiders the impression of being cold, withdrawn, and moody. But deep down, that’s because she’s bad at socializing and doesn’t know how to express her feelings…

“She slips up when she’s nervous, so she always avoids letting herself get into nervous situations. That’s why the ‘sea witch’ always comes and goes quickly and looks so carefree…

“When she gets too flustered, she has no idea how to start a conversation. It makes her seem rude, arrogant, and strange. But if someone is willing to speak up first and break the silence at that time, she’ll be very happy…”

Back in Frostholm, Duncan had always kept up his image in front of Tyrian as someone “who lost his memories because of Subspace”. Thanks to that, he could openly ask a lot of things about Lucretia. Now, that intel was finally paying off.

“Long time no see,” after giving himself a few moments to adjust, Duncan showed a faint smile and walked toward the “sea witch”. “Lucy, I’m back.”

He followed his rehearsed lines and his own understanding as he tried to play the role of “Duncan Abnomar”.

Yet even as he greeted her, a faint emotion rose quietly from deep in his heart. In that soft, blurry feeling, he once again sensed that trace of distant longing and… regret.

He was no stranger to this feeling anymore. Every body he took over would react in a similar way when it met someone or something that had mattered greatly “in life”.

This time, Duncan did not try to control or ignore the feeling. He let it flow slowly through his heart, and let it fade just as slowly.

Lucretia’s expression changed several times. No one knew what this “witch” thought about in those few short seconds. She stared at him in a daze for a moment. In the end, all her memories and all the intense emotions she had once felt settled into a single, very soft sentence:

“Dad… you were gone far too long this time…”

Duncan was quiet for a moment, then reached into his coat. “I brought you a gift.”

“Gift?” Lucretia raised her head with a slightly confused look.

Duncan stretched out his hand and slowly opened his palm.

A small silver?white hair clip with a design of waves and feathers lay quietly in the center of his hand.

Lucretia stared, stunned. She looked blankly at the little hair clip. After a while, she blinked, as if suddenly waking up, then reached out her hand with a bit of hesitation.

The hair clip was real. It felt hard to the touch and carried a faint warmth—the warmth of a living person.

The “witch” held the gift. After a very long time, she seemed to show the tiniest hint of a smile and said in a very soft voice: “You delivered this so late. It’s out of fashion now. It went out of fashion a whole century ago…”

She stood there for a moment more, then seemed to take a tiny breath.

“Thank you.”

Chapter 537:

The moment Lucretia took the small hair clip, Duncan felt something deep in his “heart” relax all of a sudden.

It was a place so hidden it was almost impossible to notice, a feeling that could not be put into words. It was like a mission that had been delayed for far too long was finally completed at last. Even if this body had forgotten what that mission actually was, the thought carved into his soul still let out a quiet sigh.

“I hope you like it,” Duncan said softly after a pause. “I’ve forgotten many things, but I remember this hair clip was for you.”

“I heard Tyrian say that,” Lucretia nodded. At some point, she realized that the hesitation and anxiety that had tangled around her for many days had all faded away. Even though she had spoken with her father through a scrying crystal before, it was clear that only facing him with her own eyes in the Mortal Realm could truly calm those worries. “Anyway, it’s good that you’ve come back to ‘this side’.”

Duncan nodded as well, then turned his gaze toward the elven scholar standing not far away, who had been trying his best to lower his presence ever since.

“Master Taran Ael,” he said with a faint, friendly smile, trying to sound as approachable as he could, “we are meeting again in the Mortal Realm. I’m glad to see you safe and sound. There are many things I want to discuss with you.”

“D?don’t call me ‘Master’. That’s far too polite,” Taran Ael quickly waved his hands. “Just call me by my name. I’ve admired you for a long time, Captain Duncan, great explorer. Uh, I mean, back when you were still alive… when you were still human… I already…”

Duncan looked at the elven scholar in silence, while Lucretia quietly pulled out a short wand that looked like a magician’s rod and pointed it at Taran Ael’s nose.

“Frog or snake?” she asked in a calm tone, saying something very dangerous.

Taran Ael raised both hands at once and gave Duncan a miserable look. “What I meant was, a century ago I already admired your fame, but sadly I never had the chance to meet you…”

Duncan hadn’t expected this elven scholar to have such an amusing personality. He couldn’t help but laugh. “Is that the truth?”

“Of course,” Taran Ael said very seriously. “As a scholar who is very interested in the borderlands, I’ve always wanted to befriend true explorers and hear from them about what lies beyond the borders of civilization. I even dreamed of sailing off myself one day, to explore the grand wall of fog. But I am destined never to complete such a great journey…”

“It’s fine. Now you have a chance to ‘befriend’ me properly,” Duncan nodded. Then he suddenly remembered something and turned to Lucretia. “Right, there’s another thing for you.”

For a moment, Lucretia did not react. Then she saw Duncan raise his hand in a small gesture.

The flaming doorway that had appeared on the deck earlier had never fully gone out. At Duncan’s motion, it suddenly swelled. A hollow opened inside

the swirling flames, and after a quick burst of fire and smoke, a giant wooden crate appeared on the deck.

A fat, snow?white pigeon with fluffy feathers stood on top of the crate.

Ai tilted its head. One eye focused on Lucretia, while the other wandered off who knew where. “Dear customer, please sign for your delivery. Don’t forget to leave a five?star review.”

Lucretia stared blankly at the scene, wondering what was going on with this pigeon. Then her gaze shifted and landed on a metal nameplate fixed to the side of the crate.

“Tyrian prepared a Spirit Realm lens for you—the highest grade,” Duncan said, pointing at the crate. “You didn’t forget, did you?”

“Ah, I… didn’t forget,” Lucretia said, her eyes sliding to the side with a guilty look. She quickly changed the subject and pointed at the pigeon strutting proudly on the crate. “This is the ‘Ai’ my brother mentioned? What did it mean by ‘five?star review’?”

“Don’t mind it. Most people can’t understand the way this pigeon talks,” Duncan waved his hand and called Ai onto his shoulder. Then he gestured for Lucretia to lead the way. “Leave the lens here on the deck for now. You can decide what to do with it later. Let’s find a place where we can talk.”

“Alright.”

Led by Lucretia, Duncan and Taran Ael entered a “parlor” in the middle deck.

It was an upper cabin with large windows, set along the ship’s side. Through the glass, a visitor could see the power systems along the flank of the Radiant Star and the ship’s stern, which looked half?spiritual and half? real, as if it were always shrouded in mist.

Duncan walked to the window, curiosity clear on his face, and looked out at the “view”. He studied this ship that looked different from the Vanished, yet carried the same eerie atmosphere—a ship of the curse, with a stern like a ghostly kingdom. After a long moment, he sighed. “This ship is nothing like the Sea Mist at all.”

Even though Duncan’s words were just a casual comment, Lucretia still looked a little uneasy. “It has been a long time. Both the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star are very different from your original designs now. To survive at the ‘border’, I made many bold changes to this ship. I hope you won’t be angry.”

“There should be changes. Change is good,” Duncan laughed. “The Vanished has changed a lot too. If you go aboard and see its interior, you’ll be shocked.”

Board the Vanished?

For a moment, Lucretia felt a bit dazed. Maybe she remembered something from long ago. Or maybe she thought of how she had already boarded the Vanished several times now, and how her elder brother contacted her from there every so often just to scare her.

But she soon came back to herself and nodded to Duncan. “I… will go.”

Then she lifted her head and raised her voice toward the door: “Lunie, you can come in.”

The door opened. Under Duncan’s curious gaze, a clockwork doll entered, pushing a small cart with drinks and snacks.

The doll’s face looked six or seven parts like Lucretia’s, but her whole body was made of metal, ceramic, and leather. With a soft ticking and faint clicking of gears, the clockwork doll walked to the table in the middle of

the parlor and gave Duncan a small bow. “It is a pleasure to see you, Old Master.”

“You’re Lunie?” Duncan couldn’t help taking a few extra glances at the strange doll. “I found your ‘sister’ Nilu in a doll shop in Pland. To be honest, you two are very different.”

“When you first saw me, I was only a one?third doll,” Lunie said, very polite, keeping her head slightly bowed. Soft ticking and clacking sounds came from inside her body. “Of course, at that time I could not think or speak. It was Mistress who gave me life.”

“…Incredible craftsmanship,” Duncan said, looking over at Lucretia. “But I also have a talking, thinking ‘doll’ on my ship now. Maybe Lunie and she can be friends.”

“I know. Brother told me about Anomaly 099,” Lucretia nodded. “Lunie is very curious about that ‘Miss Alice’ as well, but… is she really safe?”

“Perfectly safe,” Duncan waved it off. “On the Vanished, she’s the safest one there. Even a bucket could beat her in a fight…”

Lucretia: “…?”

The witch finally began to get a faint idea of what Father meant earlier when he said, “the Vanished has changed a lot too.”

At this point, Duncan finally turned his full attention to Taran Ael.

Under the elven scholar’s nervous gaze, Duncan adjusted his posture and asked seriously: “In the legends or traditional belief system of the elves, is there any term like ‘Nameless One’s Dream’?”

Taran Ael blinked. “Nameless One’s Dream?”

Then he suddenly reacted. “You mean the dream I fell into before? Are you saying… that dream has a name, ‘Nameless One’s Dream’?”

“If the intel is right, yes.”

Duncan gave a clear answer. Then he told the two of them all the intel he had forced out of the cultists with “a few tricks”. He included the possible role of the Enders working in the dark, his own rough guesses, and his earlier discussion with Agatha. He held nothing back.

As Duncan spoke, Taran Ael gradually forgot about his earlier nervousness and discomfort. He became fully focused. Even Lucretia leaned forward a little, a thoughtful look flickering across her face from time to time.

To a scholar devoted to research, this information taken from heretics sounded dangerous yet very tempting. It might be closely tied to their evil doctrines, but behind it all… there seemed to be hints of knowledge and mystery.

When Duncan finally fell silent, the room grew very quiet. The two scholars both sank into thought. After who knew how long, Lucretia was the first to break the silence: “Can we trust this intel? Ah, I’m not doubting you, but those cultists are usually very cunning. Even church inquisitors who are experts at dealing with heretics usually have to go to great lengths to pry anything out of them…”

“It’s reliable,” Duncan said, full of confidence. “I used some very effective investigation methods—ah, would you like to hear exactly what I did?”

Lucretia and Taran Ael both froze and, without even thinking, shook their heads at the same time.

“…Alright then,” Duncan said, sounding a bit disappointed. “So what are your thoughts now? Mr. Taran Ael, what guesses do you have about this ‘Nameless One’s Dream’?”

Taran Ael thought carefully, then after a few seconds he spoke, choosing his words. “There is no such term in any elven legend or traditional belief, as

far as I know. I can at least be sure the term doesn’t come from any elven language. But if we only talk about the idea of ‘dreams’… our race does have many stories related to it.”

Duncan’s interest rose at once. “Oh?”

“Have you ever heard of the Great Demon God Saslokar?”

Chapter 538: The Legends of the Elves

Great Demon God Saslokar.

A faint sense of familiarity rose in Duncan’s mind. Soon he remembered that he had indeed heard this name before—it had come up long ago, during a casual chat with Morris.

“I remember… this is the name of the ‘main god’ described in the ancient faith system unique to the Elves,” he said slowly. “This demon god has the power to control dreams and wandering souls. In your legends, this Great Demon God is even linked to the beginning of the current ‘Deep Sea era’—”

“Yes, Captain Duncan,” Taran Ael nodded. “According to those old legends, the world was originally a dream. It was created while the Great Demon God Saslokar was in a half-sleeping state. The Elves were residents born inside that dream. Our inborn mission is to serve Saslokar within the dream and prolong His sleep as much as possible, to keep the whole world from facing doomsday when the Great Demon God wakes.”

Lucretia listened carefully at the side. As a learned person, she clearly also knew something about these ancient, strange Elven legends, so different from today’s mainstream faith and branded as ‘heretical’. She could not help cutting in: “But Saslokar is destined to wake up—that is also part of the legend.”

“That’s right. The Great Demon God is destined to awaken, and His awakening means the end of the world,” Taran Ael nodded again and went on. “Most of the less mainstream belief systems have similar ‘end-of-the-world prophecies’. In most cases, they are only warnings, used to threaten believers, to strengthen their own persuasiveness and their control over the congregation.

“But the Elves’ legends are not like that. In Elven stories, this ‘world doomsday’ has already happened.

“In the legends, the end of the world began with a nightmare. Because of that nightmare, the Great Demon God saw the coming of a Great Flood. The Elves’ long-standing efforts to soothe Him lost their effect. He woke in terror, and the flood leaked out of His dream into the Mortal Realm, turning into the boundless ocean…

“After that, because of His awakening, the Great Demon God Saslokar vanished. The Elves could never return to that peaceful dreamscape. They could only survive in the endless sea left behind after the flood. That is how Elven myth explains the coming of the Deep Sea era.”

Taran Ael’s account was not very different from what Morris had once told Duncan. He simply added a few more details. After the Elven scholar finished speaking, Duncan showed a thoughtful expression.

After a few seconds, he broke the silence in a low voice: “Both your creation myths and your doomsday prophecies revolve around the element of ‘dreams’.”

“Yes. In Elven culture, ‘dreams’ always take up a very large part,” Taran Ael nodded. “We believe that inside and outside the dream are two worlds. Both worlds truly exist and can affect one another. Falling asleep and waking up is the process of traveling between these two worlds—or, in more traditional words, it is the ‘Journey of Nowhere’.”

He paused to organize his thoughts, then continued: “Since we are talking about this, I will mention one more side topic—among the Elves there is also a special congenital illness called ‘the Dreamless’.”

Duncan frowned: “The Dreamless?”

“Just like the literal meaning—people who are born unable to dream,” Taran Ael explained. “Dreaming is a mortal instinct. In our view, dreaming is as uncontrollable and unavoidable as death. Of course, some people dream more, some less. Some even think they do not dream at all—but research has shown that those people only have dreams that are too short or too shallow. When they wake up, they simply cannot remember their dreams. They still dream.

“The Dreamless are completely different from that—they truly do not dream.

“The sleep of the Dreamless is pale. After they fall asleep, there is only empty chaos. Their consciousness seems to ‘jump’ straight over the entire sleeping process. No skilled psychiatrist or priest can find the slightest trace of dreams in them.

“This completely dreamless condition only appears among the Elves. It has about a one-in-ten-thousand chance of occurring. It is inborn and cannot be cured.”

Duncan could not help sighing: “…In a race that puts such extreme importance on ‘dreams’, the Dreamless must be treated in a very special way.”

“Yes. To most Elves, the pale, empty sleep of the Dreamless is dangerous and strange, even terrifying. In history there really were many unfair treatments aimed at the Dreamless. But most of that happened before the Age of City-States,” Taran Ael said, waving his hand. “Now we no longer

target or discriminate against the Dreamless on purpose. But as you said, the influence of traditional culture is still there. They are more or less… regarded in a special way."

Duncan listened to these parts of Elven culture and legend that Nonhuman Folk found hard to learn about. When the Grand Scholar finished, Duncan thought for a moment and slowly said: "Yet among the many legends and records about dreams, there is one thing missing—the 'dream of the Nameless One'."

"One possible explanation is that the 'dream of the Nameless One' is only what those cultists call it. The thing it refers to has another name inside Elven culture," Taran Ael said. "This kind of thing is very common. Elven culture is ancient and difficult. Parts that spread outside are often misunderstood and altered by Nonhuman Folk. We cannot expect a race with an average lifespan of less than a hundred years to all understand whether a vessel with seven thousand years of history was used to hold wine or draw water."

Lucretia had been silently thinking at the side. When she heard the Grand Scholar's words, she suddenly looked up and said: "If it does 'have another name', could that so-called dream of the Nameless One actually be the same as the dream that Great Demon God Saslokar created in Elven legends?"

"The Old World?" Taran Ael frowned, then quickly shook his head. "The dream created by Saslokar is only a legend. There is no evidence it really existed. Even if it did, in this Deep Sea era it must have already broken and scattered…"

"But you and another Elf far away in Pland did both fall into a huge, strange 'dream' at the same time," Duncan reminded him. "Have you forgotten that endless forest?"

“…I did think of it,” Taran Ael said after a moment of hesitation, still very cautious with his words. “We can make such a bold assumption… but we must confirm it with enough evidence. If that dream really is the legendary ‘dream of Saslokar’, if it is the ‘Origin World’…”

“Then it won’t only be Elven society that is shaken,” Lucretia said calmly. “The entire scholarly world will be shaken.”

“Yes, the whole world,” Taran Ael said, his expression especially serious. “It would mean that among the countless guesses and mutually conflicting records, we finally have one ‘record’ about the history before the Great Annihilation that has been verified. Even if we still cannot break through the black wall that stands ten thousand years behind us, that wall would at least have a crack. Through it we could glimpse faint reflections from before the Deep Sea era.”

Duncan had, of course, thought of this as well. But he did not speak. He kept thinking in silence. Only after a long time did he ask with a trace of curiosity: “Are there any more detailed legends about the ‘Great Demon God Saslokar’?”

“Most ‘legends’ are vague and full of contradictions. Even a race like the Elves, with stable and complete inheritance, cannot avoid this,” Taran Ael said slowly. “In most legends, Saslokar is described as a giant dressed like a shepherd, holding a Gatekeeper’s cane that can measure the entire world. But some stories describe Him as a huge billy goat. The Epic of Bran Marr, kept in the city-state of Morka, says He has no form at all. He changes into any appearance in line with the imagination of those who come before Him. He is a ‘reflection’ of the most grand and awe-inspiring image in a mortal’s heart…

“But no matter which legend it is, there is one common part: Saslokar dwells at the roots of the world tree ‘Atlantis’. The giant tree Atlantis is the

first plant ever born into the world. Saslokar created it in His dream as His home. Loneliness then drove Him to shake the branches of Atlantis hard. Dust, fruit, and leaves all fell from the tree, and what fell turned into all the things in the world.

“The dust that fell from the World Tree turned into mountains and minerals. The branches and leaves of Atlantis became all kinds of birds and beasts, flowers, fish, and insects. The fruits of Atlantis turned into the first Elves. Dust does not rot, so mountains and minerals do not decay. Branches and fruit began to rot as soon as they touched the ground, so living beings in the mortal world gained the cycle of life and death.”

Taran Ael paused here, picked up the teacup that the doll Lunie had left on the table, took a sip, then went on: “That is how the Great Demon God created all things in His dream. After this first ‘creation’ was complete, Saslokar began to walk through His world.

“He strolled around Atlantis and set the rules of the mortal world with His gaze. He could circle the World Tree once every year, so Atlantis withered and flourished on a yearly cycle. Because of this, the mortal world gained clear seasons. He returned to the foot of Atlantis on the last day of every year. On that day, the Elves had to dress in their finest and go out in a grand procession to show Saslokar the skills and creations they were most proud of. If the Great Demon God felt those things were good, they would continue to exist in the dreamscape He had created, and the world would go on.”

After saying this, Taran Ael finally let out a long breath.

“That is all, Captain Duncan.”

Chapter 539: Sailing Toward sunlight

After listening to Taran Ael’s long explanation, Duncan thought for a long time.

There was no doubt that these ancient Elven legends were special in this world, even unique—simply because they were complete.

After the Great Annihilation, in the Deep Sea era, the Old World collapsed and overturned. The New Civilization broke and was rebuilt. Contact between city-states was cut off for a long time. On top of that came the many shocks of the Age of Darkness. All this caused the historical records of almost every city-state on the Boundless Sea to become fragmented. Almost no race kept any complete inheritance.

The faith in the Four Gods, which only appeared after the beginning of the Deep Sea era, developed rapidly under these conditions of broken traditions and a blank space in myths.

Yet among the Elves, the old myths were preserved and passed down. Even today, when the faith of the Four Gods covered the whole world and the old system of belief was condemned as heresy, these things still remained.

Because of their small population, the city-states occupied by the Elves made up only a small part of the Boundless Sea and were very scattered. Even so, in these few scattered Elven city-states, their culture, customs, and mythical system still showed a high degree of consistency.

And had they managed this only by relying on “long life”?

“Such a complete myth system… maybe it really reveals some of the truth about the time before the Great Annihilation,” Duncan murmured to himself.

“Many scholars have always believed so,” Taran Ael said. “The Elves are the only race that still keeps a complete ancient system of faith. Many of our old books have suffered from corruption, but the myths that we pass down by word of mouth… largely keep their original form.” He spread his hands helplessly. “Even so, we can only study them as ‘stories’. We cannot directly treat them as historical records from before the Great Annihilation.”

Duncan frowned. Some words that Morris had told him long ago rose in his mind without warning: “…because of the huge contradictions between history and the Mortal Realm.”

“Yes. Every scholar who tries to trace the Great Annihilation will face the cruel blow of ‘contradiction’,” Taran Ael sighed. “We feel this most deeply. The more complete the Elves’ myth system is, the less it can explain the world as it is now. The largest contradiction lies in this… in the process of Saslokar’s creation of the world, there is no place for humans or Senkin.”

Duncan said nothing. He only thought with a grave expression.

Taran Ael went on: “Not only in the creation myths of Saslokar. In some of our other, less complete legends, whenever they describe the world, they never mention the species ‘humans’ or ‘Senkin’ at all. You should understand—this is very abnormal.”

Duncan slowly nodded. But for some reason, the image that rose in his mind was not Elven myths.

It was the Moon.

He lifted his head and looked out the window. Pale golden sunlight spread across the sea. In the distant rising and falling waves, he could faintly see a glowing border like a cliff stretching across the water.

That was the fallen relic that Lucretia had brought back from the “border”. That was where the mysterious stone sphere lay.

“Are you going to take a look at that thing?” Lucretia was the first to notice Duncan’s gaze, and she spoke at once. “There is a temporary research facility built by Lightwind Harbor over there. I have already spoken with the people there. They can clear out all unrelated personnel from the core area.”

Duncan hesitated for a moment, then nodded lightly: “Go make the arrangements. That is why I came.”

“Alright, I will contact the research facility and have them pull the people back.”

Lucretia answered and then left the room.

Soon after she left, Duncan noticed the Radiant Star slowly turning its bow and beginning to sail toward the huge glowing orb in the distance.

For a time, only Duncan and the Elven Grand Scholar remained in the room. After a brief quiet, Taran Ael visibly grew nervous and uneasy again.

Thankfully, this time his uneasiness did not last long—before the awkward air could thicken, Duncan took the initiative to break the silence: “I heard that when the Sun went out, you tried to observe the surface of Vision 001?”

“Yes,” Taran Ael said. He laid his hands on the table in some nervousness and toyed with his thumbs. “And Lady Lucretia has always believed that my sleep is related to observing the Sun, though I do not quite agree…”

“What did you see?” Duncan asked.

“…I recorded what I saw at the time. The sheet is now with Lady Lucretia, but many key details on it have been smeared out—I did the smearing myself, but I don’t remember doing it. If you are interested, later…”

Before Taran Ael could finish, the door to the reception room opened. Lucretia, who had left not long ago, returned. “That sheet is with me.”

As she spoke, she walked back to the table. While taking a crumpled sheet of drafting paper from inside her coat, she said to Duncan: “I have left the ship in Rabby’s hands for now—it is another of my crew members. This is the sketch Master Ael drew at the time. You can take a look.”

Duncan’s expression grew serious at once as he took the paper from her. He spread it flat on the table and let his eyes move over the rough drawing.

At first glance, it was just a mass of meaningless, messy lines. Aside from the circular outline at the edge, which showed that this was indeed a drawing of Vision 001, the heavy smearing inside the circle had almost completely destroyed its original structure.

But after he studied it carefully for a while, he began to faintly feel a trace of familiarity behind those tangled strokes.

It was as if something he had once seen before—something that had left a deep impression—was hidden under those smears.

Duncan frowned, staring at it for a long time. Then he raised his head and looked at Taran Ael: “You really cannot remember anything?”

“Not at all,” Taran Ael said awkwardly. “My mind erased that part of my memory on its own. I think… it must have been very dangerous information.”

“This sheet itself does not carry any corruption, but rushing to restore its ‘true version’ could still bring danger,” Lucretia added at the side. “I originally planned to give it to the scholars at Lightwind Harbor. But after realizing the risk, I felt it would be better to hand it to you.”

“Good,” Duncan let out a small breath, and a slight smile appeared on his face. “You have started to rebuild your trust in me?”

Lucretia suddenly looked a bit nervous: “…I only felt… you were more suitable… Of course I trust you. My brother said that you now…”

“No need to say any more, Lucy,” Duncan said, shaking his head with a smile. Then he carefully put the sheet away. “I will take it back first. Later I will find a way to uncover its secret. If there is any progress, I will let you know at once.”

Lucretia seemed to let out a sigh of relief and even looked a little happy.

Duncan did not say anything else. After putting away the sketch, he went to the window and quietly watched the rolling sea outside, and the patch of “sunlight” that was slowly drawing closer at the edge of the porthole.

…

After a voyage that was not very long, the Radiant Star gradually approached the glowing fallen relic floating on the sea near Lightwind Harbor.

Now, the ship was sailing past the temporary harbor beside it.

Duncan stood on the foredeck and watched as the vast golden radiance loomed ahead like a sky-high cliff, growing larger and larger in his field of view.

This was his first time seeing with his own eyes this “fallen relic” that had only existed in Tyrian’s description—and he was seeing it at such close

range. The pressure from the approaching giant and the strange feeling from the unreal curtain of light mixed together, and even he felt a brief moment of breathlessness.

He could easily imagine just how much of a shock Lucretia had brought to the Elves here when she first dragged this thing back near Lightwind Harbor.

But by now, the Elves had clearly grown used to this “neighbor”.

“This harbor is the ‘research facility’ you mentioned before?” Duncan raised his arm, pointed at the temporary floating harbor on the nearby sea, and asked Lucretia, who stood beside him.

“Yes,” Lucretia nodded. “Because we were worried that some things inside the fallen relic might be dangerous, we put all the research work out on the sea. Master Taran Ael is one of the main people in charge of this harbor. Also, there is a small permanent station set up in the central area of the fallen relic, but everyone there has already been called back now.”

“That is understandable—after all, not everyone can handle being so close to a ‘subspace shadow’,” Duncan said with a laugh. “Mr. Taran Ael has already done very well.”

Lucretia hurried to explain: “It was not all because of that. The way you look now… I mean, after you have drawn back your flames, you really do not look much different from an ordinary person. Most people would not recognize this face of yours… I was mainly worried that unrelated people would disturb you…”

“It’s alright. Don’t be so nervous all the time,” Duncan said, waving his hand with a smile. “It is normal for some people to be afraid. I am used to it.”

Lucretia quickly nodded, then lifted her gaze to look at the huge wall of light that was now very close. “We are about to enter the glowing orb. We will have to sail carefully from here. I have to go steer the ship myself.”

“Mm, go ahead.”

Lucretia nodded. Then, with a bang, she turned into countless fluttering, colorful pieces of paper that spiraled toward the bridge.

Duncan stared in surprise. It was his first time seeing this strange power of Lucretia’s. As the paper pieces flew in front of him, he reached out on impulse and caught one, then held it up to his eyes to examine it curiously.

The next second, he heard a startled cry from the air. All the flying paper pieces suddenly rushed back together with a bang and reformed into Lucretia’s shape.

The witch landed on the deck in a sorry state.

And she slid quite a distance.

Chapter 540: To the Moon

Lucretia slid several meters across the deck. It happened so suddenly that Duncan did not even have time to react, much less understand what had just happened.

Only when the Sea Witch scrambled back to her feet did he hurriedly let go of the scrap of paper in his hand.

The colorful scrap shot away with a soft whoosh and quickly sank into Lucretia's hair. She still stood there in place, a little dazed, with no clear expression on her face.

She had probably been stunned by the fall.

"Lucy…" With embarrassment deep enough to scrape a hole in the deck, and a faint sense of guilt, Duncan walked carefully up to the still?dazed Sea Witch and asked: "Are you alright?"

Lucretia gave a little jolt, as if she finally woke from the daze caused by the fall. She slowly turned her head. Her expression shifted from blank to shocked. She stared at Duncan in disbelief for a long time before finally breaking the silence: "How did you do that?"

"Ah?" Duncan did not follow. "Do what?"

"You grabbed… the 'shadow'…" Lucretia spoke slowly, as if struggling to find words for something too abstract. Then she raised her arm. Starting from her fingertips, part of her arm quickly broke apart into drifting,

colored scraps of paper that whirled around her. “Could you try it again so I can watch?”

Still puzzled, Duncan reached out and casually snatched one of the colorful scraps.

In the next second, the fluttering paper suddenly collapsed and came back together as Lucretia’s arm. Her face changed again in surprise.

“This is unbelievable!” The Sea Witch stared wide?eyed at Duncan. “Nothing like this has ever happened before. Can you tell me how you did it?”

Watching this daughter he had more or less picked up for free suddenly light up with a Researcher’s excitement, Duncan himself still had no idea what was going on. He frowned at the colorful scrap in his hand, looking completely confused: “Is that really so hard? They’re just bits of paper flying in the air…”

“They can’t be caught, Dad,” Lucretia said, spreading her hands. “If Phantom Wind could be broken just because someone grabbed one piece of paper, how could I use it as my main way of moving around? They’re all phantoms. In theory they pass through every barrier…”

“I didn’t know that,” Duncan shrugged. “I just saw the paper and got curious, so I grabbed one to take a look. Sorry… did it hurt when you fell? Did you hit anything?”

Lucretia froze for a moment.

It seemed that no one had spoken to her with that kind of concern for a very, very long time.

Ever since she had become the powerful Sea Witch, a bearer of the curse who made many people afraid, and the captain of a ghost ship, she had no longer heard words like this.

It made her feel a little awkward.

“I… I’m fine,” she said, shaking her head with a strange look on her face. She tried to push down the awkward feeling and turn her mind toward thinking. “You can grab phantoms… is that one of your powers now? What is its essence? Is it about understanding the deep layers of the world? Or is it because of Subspace?”

Lucretia really sank into thought. Her instinct to explore the unknown made her forget her embarrassment at once. She muttered as she thought: “… Could it be that, on the layer of Subspace, there is no real difference between matter and phantoms from the Mortal Realm? That everything in the mortal world is just the same kind of ‘concept’ in front of Subspace… Was Claude Divens’s theory right? That all things are ‘concepts’ and form unified projections in Subspace…”

Duncan listened to the Sea Witch muttering beside him. At last he could not help interrupting her: “Lucy… you can study this some other time.”

The Sea Witch snapped back to herself at once, but she still stared at Duncan with wide, unblinking eyes.

Duncan lowered his head and looked at the colored scrap in his hand. His own thoughts began to churn as well.

He had not thought that these bright scraps of paper were such special “things”. From Lucretia’s reaction, his casual move just now seemed enough to be called “world?shaking”.

He had caught a phantom—yet Duncan knew he had no power to catch phantoms.

He simply had not known that these scraps were phantoms.

His thoughts rose and fell. Old events and guesses floated up from his memories. Certain “things” appeared in his mind—it was the fish.

After who knew how long, he spoke at last in a low voice, almost to himself: “Its essence… might be ‘I don’t know’…”

Lucretia heard her Father mutter, but she was completely lost: “What do you mean? Are you saying you don’t know what this power really is?”

Duncan came back to himself. He opened his mouth as if he wanted to explain something to his daughter, but after hesitating several times, he still shook his head.

“It means something else, but I don’t know how to explain it to you—Lucy, I’ll tell you another time when we have the chance. For now we still have other matters.”

He turned his head and looked at the great “wall of light” that had already come before the bow of the Radiant Star, pressing down on them with its vast, heavy presence.

“Take me to see that stone sphere first.”

Lucretia nodded, but did not leave. She still stood there, looking at her Father with a tangled, complicated gaze.

Duncan frowned in confusion: “Is there something else?”

Lucretia hesitated, then carefully raised a hand and pointed: “Could you… give that back to me first?”

Duncan looked down and saw that he was still holding the colored scrap she had split off for their little “experiment” earlier.

His face stiffened at once. He let go as he coughed and apologized: “Ah—sorry.”

The scrap floated up, then shot into Lucretia’s arm, filling in a patch that had been dull and colorless.

The Sea Witch watched this with a strange look. Then she nodded to Duncan, turned, and dissolved into a cloud of swirling colored paper, ready to fly toward the bridge. But she had barely gone half a meter before she stopped, her figure re?forming. She turned back to him uneasily: “Please don’t grab me this time…”

Duncan’s face grew awkward: “…Of course.”

Lucretia nodded again and turned away, then turned back once more, still uneasy: “If you’re curious, we can talk first and do the experiment together next time. Really, don’t just grab me.”

Duncan spread his hands, half amused and half helpless: “I won’t grab you. I’m not a little child.”

Lucretia let out a soft “oh”, then hesitated for a good while as she turned. At last she sighed: “I’ll just walk there instead…”

And so the Sea Witch walked all the way to the distant bridge.

Duncan watched her back with a strange expression as she walked away, and could not help thinking:

Luckily, Master Taran Ael had been too nervous to come out on deck with him and was still resting in his cabin. Otherwise, this scene would not be just a warm father?daughter moment plus a little embarrassment.

The Sea Witch might well have chosen to silence him on the spot—and then Taran Ael really would have died on this ship.

His messy thoughts circled once in his mind. Duncan let out a slow breath, and his mood finally calmed. At the same time, under its captain’s own hand, the Radiant Star made a slight adjustment to its heading and then sailed straight into the vast “curtain of light”.

Pale golden sunlight, like some kind of solid crystal yet without the least resistance, filled his view and slowly swallowed the Radiant Star.

Duncan stood at the very end of the foredeck. He watched calmly as the sunlight swept toward him and then drowned him completely.

He tried to guess what this sunlight really was. He raised his hands a little, as if to feel its “touch”.

On the way here, he had already heard Lucretia share much information about this glowing fallen relic. He also learned that, during the time when the Sun went out, this glowing geometric body had kept sending out regular light?signals. There was a lot of information—yet not one piece could explain the “moon” at the center of the glowing geometric body.

Duncan narrowed his eyes slightly.

Small shadows appeared in his field of vision.

They were the things Lucretia had mentioned before: the research station the Elves had built at the center of the glowing geometric body, and the mysterious stone sphere that sat beside it.

The station was a two?storey building put up on a floating platform. The stone sphere floated less than a few meters away from that platform. Temporary walkways and many steel cables linked the two, holding the platform steady.

As the distance shrank, more and more details on the stone sphere came into Duncan’s view.

Now, at last, he confirmed it here in the Mortal Realm.

Those familiar markings. Those plains, lowlands, and ring?shaped mountains in light and shadow. The image that had appeared again and

again in his recent memories, that he had seen more than once in books and on the internet—the Moon.

“It really is it…”

A vague, nameless mix of feelings spread through his heart. It was not surprise; Duncan had already been surprised before. It was not confusion either; he had already been puzzling over this for a long time before today.

In this moment, he was only confirming and witnessing something that had entangled him for a long time. A strange fact he could not understand and could hardly accept now stood before him in a way that left no doubt.

The Radiant Star slowed. Under Lucretia’s control, this living ghost ship—just like the Vanished—came to a stop with unbelievable precision only a few meters away from the stone sphere.

Duncan walked to the edge of the deck. From here he could see every tiny pattern on the surface of the stone sphere.

He became more and more sure. This sphere, only about ten meters across, had an astonishing level of “accuracy”. It was so fine and matched the surface details of the Moon so well that… it did not look at all like the “scale model” he had first imagined.

It felt as if it was the real Moon itself, compressed down to this size.

Chapter 541: The Chasm

Duncan knew his idea was bold and strange, so strange that even in this uncanny age of the Deep Sea it would sound far?fetched. The thought that a real heavenly body had been transformed into the ten?meter?wide stone sphere before him and made to float on the sea went beyond mere wild fantasy.

But once the thought appeared, he found it hard to drive it out of his mind. No matter how impossible it seemed, he could not stop thinking about it.

Because… it really was too similar. Not only in its looks, but also in a strong sense of intuition. There was even a strange feeling of familiarity, as if it crossed time itself and the very layers of the world, all surging in his mind.

Duncan stared at the pale sphere before him. For a moment he even felt that he had gone back to that familiar world and was using his gaze to look down on the moon over his homeland.

He stood there, staring fixedly at the Moon that floated beside the hull of the Radiant Star. His expression stayed frozen for a long time, until he heard footsteps at his side and Lucretia’s voice reached his ears: “Father, this is it.”

Duncan turned his head. He himself did not realize how strange his face looked in that moment: “Ah… yes. This is it…”

Of course Lucretia noticed the oddness in his expression and tone. She seemed to tense up a little, then spoke with concern: “Are you alright? Your

face doesn’t look very good… is there something wrong with this stone sphere?”

“It’s… fine. Thank you for asking, Lucy,” Duncan waved his hand and tried hard to steady his expression. Then he turned again and pointed at the stone sphere. “It…”

He stopped.

He had no idea how to explain this to Lucretia. He did not know how to describe the idea of “the Moon”, how to speak of another world, or how to explain his reaction now, just like when he had stood before Tyrian. He did not even know how to start explaining what a “planet” was.

So he only opened his mouth, then forced himself to change the subject: “After it fell, did anything change about it? Was it like this from the start?”

“Yes. It has been like this from the beginning,” Lucretia said at once. She briefly described how she had first found this fallen relic, then added some details about moving it to Lightwind Harbor: “…It floats in the air at a fixed height above the sea by some unknown mechanism. If left alone, it stays perfectly still, but a ship can drag it with outside force. The inside is solid and dense. Several careful samples showed that its inner texture is similar to stone, but so far we have only managed to take material from the outer layers—the deeper we go, the harder it gets. The drill simply will not go any further…”

Duncan listened quietly, then asked: “What else? What have you found?”

“We have also tried to solve the mystery of the light around it,” Lucretia went on. “The huge geometric glowing orb wrapped around the stone sphere keeps releasing sunlight, enough to light an entire city?state. Yet this light does not come from the stone sphere itself, or at least not in any way

we understand. The radiance is generated directly in the nearby space and then spreads outward evenly.

“To test this, we built a very large screen and covered the stone sphere completely. It proved that this had no effect at all on the glowing geometric body or the sunlight over the surrounding sea…

“And we also confirmed that the surface of the stone sphere is covered by a very, very fine dust. It is attached to the sphere by some unknown force. We can scrape it off for samples, but without outside interference it never falls away from the sphere, not even the dust at the bottom. It is as if some invisible force holds it there…”

Lucretia did her best to explain to Duncan the various tests the Scholars had run on this stone sphere and all the information she knew so far.

All the while, she watched the changes in Duncan’s face, trying to guess what feelings were hidden under his overly serious, heavy expression.

But she could not see through it. All of her Father’s thoughts seemed wrapped in a thick fog, hidden behind that familiar yet distant, stern face. The only thing she was sure of was that her Father cared very, very much about this stone sphere—far more than she and Tyrian had thought.

After a long silence, Duncan finally spoke: “You have taken many samples?”

“Yes. We scraped surface samples from many parts of the stone sphere, and this sampling is still going on,” Lucretia nodded. “The deeper parts are extremely hard and almost impossible to sample, but the outer layer is a bit more loose. We can scrape off grayish?white fragments that behave just like common stone dust…”

Here she paused for a moment and looked at Duncan with some hesitation. Then she raised a hand and pointed to the floating platform not far away

that held the research station for the stone sphere: “Would you like to come over there and take a look with me?”

“…Alright.”

Duncan and Lucretia went to the research station the Elves had built. From the upper level of the station they crossed a connecting bridge to a small platform fixed directly to the surface of the stone sphere.

A ten?meter diameter was nothing for a heavenly body. But as an object hanging right in front of them, it was still a giant. Even without counting the height it floated above the sea, the sphere’s own size was taller than a three?storey house.

The Elves had fixed a platform to the “waist” of this huge thing, bracing it with a ring around the sphere and a series of bolts and slanting supports. The platform was small, only a few square meters, but enough to stand on.

Duncan stood on the platform, reached out his hand, and gently touched that… Moon.

A rough, cold feeling came from his fingertips, as if he were stroking a stone.

He drew his hand back and looked at the little bit of gray?white dust on his fingertips. He rubbed his fingers together, letting the dust slowly fall.

Some of the dust drifted toward the sphere and settled back on its surface.

“This phenomenon puzzles us too,” Lucretia said beside him. “The dust scraped from the sphere seems to be attracted back to it. When it gets close enough, the fragments return to the surface on their own. But this pull exists only between the stone sphere and its own material. We tested other light powders…”

Duncan made a quiet sound in reply but said nothing more.

“I heard my brother say that you called this strange stone sphere ‘the Moon’,” Lucretia said, watching Duncan’s reaction with care. “And you seemed very excited when you first saw it… Do you know something about this stone sphere?”

“It…” Duncan hesitated for a moment, then finally spoke slowly. “It does not look the way I know it. It should be very big. Much bigger than it is now…”

“Very big?” Lucretia blinked. “Bigger than the Vanished?”

“Much bigger than that.”

“Bigger than the Four Gods Church’s Pilgrimage Ark? Or bigger than a city?state?”

Duncan shook his head: “Bigger. Bigger than you can even imagine.”

“…Could it even be bigger than the Boundless Sea?”

“I have never measured the Boundless Sea, but… perhaps,” Duncan said softly, almost to himself. “Perhaps it is even larger than the Boundless Sea. Because this ‘boundless’ sea is, in truth, only a cage ringed round by mist.”

Lucretia’s eyes widened.

She did not know why, but in that instant she suddenly thought of her childhood. The questions they had just asked and answered seemed to rush back a whole century of time and stir memories long asleep in the depths of her mind. She dimly remembered that, many, many years ago, she had asked her Father similar questions.

Back then she had asked her Father how big the Boundless Sea really was.

Her Father had told her that the sea was very large, larger than the Vanished, larger than any city?state. As its name said, it was wide without end and could hold a person’s whole life of curiosity and urge to explore.

She had held that answer deep in her heart, and later followed in her Father's footsteps to become an Explorer, a "border Scholar". As one of the Homeless Fleet, she had followed her Father to many places, including the strange and distant border. She felt that the Father of her childhood had not lied to her—this sea really was very large.

Yet now her Father was telling her that the "Boundless Sea" was only a cage surrounded by fog.

The stone sphere before her, only ten meters wide, was supposed to be larger than the Boundless Sea.

Lucretia narrowed her eyes and raised her head to look up at the Moon before her. She tried her best to imagine it being larger than the Boundless Sea, and for the first time she felt how limited her imagination was. She could not understand what her Father said, and she could not even picture it.

"A Moon that big… how great a space would you need to hold it?" she could not help asking. "Like you said, it would be even bigger than this world…"

The Boundless Sea was not the whole world.

This thought rose in Duncan's mind by instinct, but he forced himself not to say it aloud.

Because he had never truly measured this world, and had never passed through the mist called the border.

He did not dare say for certain whether the Boundless Sea really was the whole of this world.

And Lucretia was destined to never understand what a universe big enough to hold countless stars would look like.

Even though she had a ship, and that ship's name was the Radiant Star.

“…I’m sorry, Lucy,” Duncan finally let out a soft breath. He turned his head and fixed his gaze on the Sea Witch’s eyes. “I have no way to explain this to you.”

Chapter 542: Alice’s Simple Theory

Since their “reunion”, this was the first time Lucretia saw such a complex, heavy, yet warm expression on her Father’s face.

Before this, Father had smiled at her, and he had shown many human-like gestures. But for some reason, she always felt a faint wrongness behind those smiles and actions. It always felt like a “kind face” he tried to put on after losing his memories in Subspace, a careful act that kept her faintly uneasy.

Yet in this moment, she finally saw something truly from the heart on his face – a touch of guilt, and a regret no outsider could easily understand.

She did not know whether that guilt was really meant for her.

“I still don’t understand enough,” the witch said with a soft sigh. “I thought I had more or less caught up with you.”

“…the Vanished finally fell into Subspace. It’s a good thing you didn’t catch up,” Duncan shook his head. He gave the quietly floating “Moon” one last look, then turned toward the gangway leading off the platform. “Let’s go back, Lucy.”

Lucretia was a little surprised: “You’re not going to study it a bit longer?”

“I’m not a scholar, and I don’t have proper methods or equipment for research,” Duncan waved a hand. “I only came because I wanted to see it with my own eyes. As for how to uncover its secrets, that’s for the professional scholars.”

He paused, then added: “I’ll be staying in Lightwind Harbor for a while. I’ll keep an eye on your progress on the ‘Moon’ at all times. Also, if any other elves show the same situation as Taran Ael, tell me at once.”

“I understand,” Lucretia nodded at once. Then she hesitated and asked: “About your arrival… can I tell Governor Sara Mell? Of course, I won’t tell anyone else casually…”

“As you like,” Duncan nodded. “Tell whoever you want – however they react has nothing to do with me.”

Lucretia lowered her head slightly: “Yes.”

A short while later, on the Vanished, which was lying on the sea outside the glowing geometric body, a whirling door of flame suddenly opened on the foredeck.

The door opened with sharp popping from the flames, and Duncan stepped out from within. Alice, who was nearby hugging a big mop and scrubbing the deck together with several other mops, instantly dropped what she was doing and ran over happily: “Captain, you’re back!”

Duncan flicked his hand and scattered the flames behind him. He looked at the doll in front of him, clutching a mop and grinning from ear to ear, and gave a simple nod: “Mm. I’m back.”

“Did it go well?” Alice tossed the mop aside without thinking and looked at the captain, excited. “You were gone for so, so long. Did you talk a lot with Miss Lucretia? Did you go to that ‘ball’ thing? What does it look li—ah!”

The mop Alice had thrown aside suddenly jumped up. It smacked the excited doll on the head with its wooden handle, then hopped and clattered away across the deck to rinse itself in a bucket.

Alice clutched her head, staring at Duncan in confusion and hurt: “Why did it hit me?! It almost knocked my head off…”

Duncan looked at this simple, straightforward doll – her bright smile just now, her baffled grievance now – and without even noticing, the stuffy gloom and sense of loss in his chest eased a little.

Alice still felt wronged.

"…You'd better check if that mop is for scrubbing the deck, or if it 'works' in the dining room," Duncan laughed and reached out to press her head. Then he asked, curious: "There's something I've always wanted to ask you – the mops and buckets on this ship can clean the deck on their own. Why do you insist on doing it yourself?"

"I'm helping!" Alice straightened her back proudly. "It's so tiring for them to scrub all by themselves!"

Duncan's eyelid twitched. He silently turned his gaze away and looked at the mops and buckets in the distance, racing over the deck as if terrified that if they slowed down by even a step, some doll would grab them to 'help'. After a moment of silence, he shook his head: "If you're happy… if you're all happy, that's fine."

Alice nodded in a muddled way. Then she saw Duncan turn as if to head back to the captain's cabin and couldn't help asking: "Captain, are you going back to rest?"

"…Yes. I'm a bit tired."

"Captain…" Alice still looked uneasy. She walked over and tugged on Duncan's sleeve. "Are you alright?"

"Why do you ask?" Duncan stopped in puzzlement and turned his head to look at the not-so-bright doll.

"Because you've been sighing a lot these past two days. And you've been spending more time in the captain's cabin than outside – even Miss Nina thinks you have something on your mind, but she's too shy to ask you,"

Alice answered honestly. “And just now, when you came back, your face looked bad, like… you had a lot of things bottled up inside. But you look better now than you did a moment ago.”

Duncan looked at the doll in front of him in surprise.

He had not expected Alice, who usually seemed carefree and scatterbrained, to notice all this, much less to grab him and say all of it straight out.

Maybe it was exactly because she never thought about many things that she did not know how to hesitate or hold back?

Some half-serious thoughts flickered through Duncan’s mind, but when he looked at the doll still full of worry and confusion, he didn’t know what to say.

After all, even when he faced the well-read Lucretia, there were too many things he could not explain clearly.

“You wouldn’t understand,” Duncan said at last after a brief silence, shaking his head. “It’s very complicated, so complex that it can’t really be explained to anyone. Not just you – even Morris probably couldn’t understand.”

Alice only blinked, then spoke without hesitation: “You can still tell me.”

Duncan didn’t know whether to laugh or cry: “Didn’t I just say you wouldn’t understand…”

“But there are lots of things you say that I don’t understand anyway,” Alice said as if it was the most natural thing in the world. “There’s a lot I don’t understand, but you still tell me. I’m really good at listening to people talk about things. I’ll listen whether I get it or not…”

Duncan’s expression suddenly turned a little strange. Hearing this silly doll speak so bluntly, even with a hint of “pride” in her odd logic, he could not

find any way to refute her for a moment.

Alice kept staring straight at the “captain” in front of her. She did not think it was embarrassing that she usually could not understand many things, and she did not feel there was anything wrong with what she was saying now. She thought of it, she was curious, so she said it.

If there was something in your heart, you just said it out loud – in Alice’s simple view of the world, that was how everything worked.

She suddenly ran off, hurried to fetch a big wooden barrel about half her own height, and set it down on the deck near the rail. Then she brought another barrel and set it beside the first.

She nimbly climbed onto one of the barrels, sat down, and waved at Duncan with a smile: “Captain, you should sit too. Miss Vanna said if you let the wind blow on you and look at the sea, you’ll feel much better.”

Duncan hesitated for a moment, then suddenly smiled.

This doll was trying – using her limited knowledge and experience – to find a way to lift the captain’s spirits, even just a little.

Duncan walked over and sat on the barrel beside Alice.

His mood did not change just because the sea breeze blew over him – but it did get a little better.

“Alice.”

“Mm?”

“I want to ask you something,” Duncan said. At first, he had been trying to figure out how to explain the ideas of the “Moon” and the “starry sky” in a way Alice could understand. Now he suddenly realized he did not need to explain those complicated things to her at all. “Let’s say you live in a certain place, and there is something that belongs only to that place. It

absolutely can’t come from anywhere else or belong anywhere else. As soon as you see it, you know it comes from there…”

Alice thought for a moment, then asked curiously: “Like how I live on the Vanished now, and you’re the only captain of the Vanished?”

Duncan froze for a second, then said, a bit unsure: “Your example isn’t quite right… but you can understand it that way.”

“Oh. So then what?”

“…Then you leave that place, and you can’t go back,” Duncan’s voice sank slightly. “You go to a very far and strange place. Everything there is different from home. You live there for a while and try to find a way back. But all of a sudden, you see that ‘thing’ – the thing that should only exist in your homeland, that should never appear in this foreign place no matter what…”

When Duncan finished speaking, Alice was still sitting there, blankly thinking. But she hadn’t thought for long before she suddenly broke into a smile.

“Then I must have gone back to the Vanished!”

“Gone back to the Vanished?”

“You said I could understand it that way,” Alice said. “You’re the only captain of the Vanished. One day, I get sent somewhere very far from the Vanished, and I can’t find my way back to the ship. Then you suddenly appear in front of me again. That means I’ve gone home! As long as you’re there, that’s the Vanished.”

The doll beamed, looking at Duncan with full confidence.

“You said that thing can only appear in ‘your homeland’. If it’s in front of you now, that means you’re at home right now!”

Alice finished her theory, then shuffled around on the barrel, turning so she faced the sea. She propped her chin in both hands, leaned forward, and smiled brightly:

“Captain, was that a trick question?”

Duncan was a little stunned.

He stared blankly at the doll on the barrel opposite him. When the sea breeze swept by, Alice’s silver hair lifted and fluttered, like her forever bright and lively mood.

Then he laughed.

“Yes, it was a trick question – and we both figured it out,” he said with a smile as he jumped down from the barrel. “Also, there’s one more thing.”

“Mm?”

“That pose isn’t very stable.”

Still leaning forward with her chin in her hands, Alice blinked in confusion: “Huh?”

The next second, she heard a small click at her neck.

“Pop -”

With two dull thumps, Alice hit the deck in two pieces. Right after that, the deck rang with her trademark stuttering cry:

“Captain, he-help, help… help…”

Chapter 543: True Form

In the crew quarters below the deck, Shirley sat in her room, frowning at the spread-out workbooks on her desk and sighing over and over.

“So many… how am I ever going to finish…”

“If you keep sighing, you’ll never finish,” Dog muttered beside her. “And it’s not that much. You only have this pile because you drag it out and don’t do it every day. Even Miss Alice manages to finish these exercises on time every day, you know?”

“Does the way she just writes whatever pops into her head on the page count as ‘finishing’?” Shirley rolled her eyes, then dropped her head onto the desk. Her voice came out muffled as she mumbled: “I want to go ashore and play. I want to go into the city-state and buy things. I want to eat something good… Nina said Lightwind Harbor has a ton of great food, food from all over the world…”

Dog had gotten used to this sort of muttering many years ago. It shook its head, completely unmoved: “Captain said you can go ashore to play when you finish all the homework you’ve been putting off.”

Shirley pouted, glanced at the workbooks on the table, and thought for a bit. Then her eyes lit up with a mischievous glint. She bent down carefully toward Dog, who was sprawled on the floor: “Hey, how about you help me? These questions must be really easy for you…”

But before Shirley could finish, before Dog could even respond, a voice suddenly came from the mirror on the desk: “I’m watching.”

Shirley let out an exaggerated, miserable “Ah—”, looked up at Agatha’s figure appearing in the mirror, and almost seemed about to cry: “Can’t you watch someone else for once? Why do you pop out of the mirror no matter what I’m doing?”

Agatha in the mirror looked very serious: “Because the captain told me to watch you while you work.”

Shirley gave a long, hopeless sigh and buried her head back into the workbooks. After rubbing her face over the pages a few times, she suddenly looked up again: “Then can’t you help me a little…”

“No,” Agatha replied without hesitation.

Shirley began to argue: “That’s not how it goes in the stories! In the stories, the magic mirror knows everything. As long as you ask it something, it tells you the answer…”

Agatha frowned: “What strange story is that?”

“Captain told it to Nina, and Nina told it to me.”

Agatha had been about to dismiss it as nonsense, but her expression suddenly turned solemn. After thinking for a few seconds, she looked straight into Shirley’s eyes and asked: “The captain really told Nina a story about a ‘magic mirror’?”

“Y-yeah,” Shirley answered, now a bit nervous, not sure why Agatha had become so serious. “He told it just a couple of days ago…”

Agatha fell into deep thought, muttering under her breath: “He set me to dwell in the mirrors on the ship… so there was another meaning behind it…”

Shirley did not follow at all: “Uh… huh?”

Agatha didn’t answer. After thinking hard for a while, the “Gatekeeper in the mirror” finally raised her head and glanced at Shirley: “Which problem can’t you do?”

Shirley thought for a second, then pushed the workbooks forward: “…This whole book.”

“This book?!”

“Yeah. If that’s too much, I can do the quick mental arithmetic part at the front…”

“Do it yourself!”

Back in the captain’s cabin, Duncan suddenly looked up with a puzzled expression, as if listening to distant sounds.

On the chart table, Goathead turned his gaze toward him at once: “Is something wrong?”

“I think I ‘heard’ Agatha’s voice,” Duncan said casually. Of course, he hadn’t really “heard” anything. The ship was simply passing him information from every corner of the Vanished. “She seems to be in Shirley’s room, and she’s pretty worked up.”

“Do we need to go check? Or should I call her over?”

“No,” Duncan shook his head. “Everyone who’s ever been put in charge of watching Shirley do her homework ends up worked up. You could even see it as a kind of mental training…”

Goathead gave a small “oh”, and it was hard to tell whether he actually understood the joke. Duncan silently felt out the state of every part of the Vanished again, then walked to the desk and sat down, letting out a quiet breath: “It’s about time Shirley and Nina went ashore to relax. Lucretia is

heading back to Lightwind Harbor anyway. We'll have her take them along."

Goathead watched the captain's movements and expression closely. At last, it couldn't help speaking: "You seem to be in a good mood?"

"Maybe it's because I've figured some things out. Or maybe it's just that I've put them down for now." Duncan raised his eyebrows. In his mind, Alice's bright, sunny face appeared all on its own, and the corners of his mouth curved in a faint smile. Then he shook his head and reached into his coat, taking out the "sketch" he had received from Lucretia.

Now that the gloom in his heart had cleared, it was time to study what exactly Taran Ael had drawn in the notes he left after observing Vision 001.

"What is that?" Seeing Duncan's action, Goathead immediately turned its head curiously. The obsidian-black eyes seemed to glimmer faintly.

"This is a sketch Taran Ael drew after observing the surface of Vision 001," Duncan said. He unfolded the paper and held it up near the oil lamp to see it more clearly. "It might hide the true appearance of the Sun's surface – but Taran Ael smeared out the most important details himself."

Goathead froze for a moment and let out a vague sound: "…Oh."

"I thought you'd warn me right away about how dangerous this is, like you always used to," Duncan said, a bit surprised by Goathead's reaction. He lifted his eyelids to look at the thing. "Why aren't you nagging this time?"

"In the past I worried about your safety. Now I only worry about the safety of those foolish enough to oppose you," Goathead said at once, flattering him with great skill. "A mere sketch could never threaten the great Captain Duncan, even if it showed the true form of the Elder Gods. Besides, the one who drew it was only a mortal. How much truth could that Taran Ael really glimpse?"

Duncan ignored this string of obvious flattery and focused on the drawing instead. But no matter how long he studied it, flipping it back and forth, he still could not make anything out behind all the wild smudges.

He even felt that those seemingly random strokes were like some kind of powerful “seal”. On the level of occult studies, they “covered” the original image on the paper, rather than simply being a layer of ink that blocked the eye.

In the middle of his thoughts, an idea suddenly stirred in Duncan’s mind.

A “seal” that actually carried power?

He lowered his head again and carefully studied the crisscrossing lines and thick patches of ink on the draft.

Taran Ael was a seasoned and experienced scholar, and a devout believer of the God of Wisdom Rahm. He suffered from a body full of ailments thanks to his awful habits, but his skill in occult studies was undeniably deep.

If a grand scholar like that had truly noticed something extremely dangerous while observing Vision 001, he would have tried at once to use more “professional” methods to contain that danger, even if his sanity had already started to slip…

The ink on this sheet probably wasn’t just random smearing. That meant there was no way to see what lay beneath it by ordinary means.

This was actually a “secret letter” that had been treated with extraordinary power.

Duncan frowned slightly as a vague idea rose in his heart. Then he turned his head and fixed his gaze on the oil lamp beside him.

Under his gaze, the flame in the oil lamp suddenly jumped, then quickly turned a ghostly green.

The fire of his spirit form swelled and burned, rising even out of the opening at the top of the lamp.

After a brief hesitation, Duncan picked up the sketch and held it over the lamp, in the heart of the spirit form fire.

In an instant, the roaring green flames swallowed the entire sheet.

There really was some kind of extraordinary “disguise” clinging to it.

Goathead cried out in alarm at the sight: “Why did you burn it?!”

“The fire of my spirit form only burns away the ‘distorted’ parts,” Duncan said calmly, giving a glance to the panicking Goathead. With a small flick of his wrist, he quenched the flames leaping on the paper. Beneath them, the fragile draft was indeed still whole. “This is what it really looks like.”

As he spoke, he lifted the fire-treated sheet to his eyes and looked at the pattern that had reappeared.

The next second, his expression froze.

Goathead immediately noticed the change on the captain’s face. Worried and curious, it twisted its neck, trying to see. But from its angle, it couldn’t make out the front of the page, so it could only shout: “What’s on it? Are you alright? Is it…”

Duncan finally snapped out of his daze. He drew his gaze away from the paper, looked at Goathead with a strange expression, and said: “…It’s the true form of the Elder Gods.”

Goathead: “?!”

Duncan did not say anything more. He slowly lowered his head again and studied the drawing on the sheet with full attention – that sphere locked inside two rings of runes, that shape shrouded in dark shadows, its surface

veined with hideous threads like blood and cracks, as if it were glaring in rage…

An eye.

The true body of Vision 001 was a gigantic eyeball, sealed inside a shell of darkness.

Chapter 544: dusk

The captain’s cabin fell into silence.

Duncan still stared hard at the huge, eerie eyeball on the draft paper.

It was drawn with almost insane, messy strokes, yet it was unbelievably accurate and vivid. Anyone only needed one glance to understand what every line on that page meant. It was as if the truth of that thing was already woven into every element that formed the picture.

In those wild, tangled strokes, the huge eyeball had a deep, dark pupil, and the outlines of blood vessels and nerve clusters could just be made out. Outside the eyeball there was clearly a layer of dim material. Taran Ael had used many thin, careful lines to??that covering layer, as if he had tried his best to restore what it really was. The only message Duncan got from the drawing was that it was a “shell with a complex structure”.

It was an eye sealed inside a shell that looked like a gemstone.

Creaking sounds came from the side. Goathead, fixed at the edge of the enchanted sea chart table, twisted his neck in great unease. He seemed to want to take a look at the paper, yet he kept hesitating.

After a long moment, he finally spoke in a hesitant tone: “Captain… what does it look like, exactly?”

“It is an eye.” Duncan stayed silent for a few seconds, then began to explain the contents of the draft to Goathead, choosing his words as he went: “From the structure, it looks very much like a human eye. You can see the blood

vessels and nerve clusters. It is sealed inside a spherical shell, and the shell looks like something man-made…”

Listening to Duncan’s description, Goathead became quieter than he had ever been in his entire existence.

Only after a long time did he crackle uneasily and make a nervous sound: “That really is… a terrifying sight… Vision 001’s true form is such a huge eyeball?! Then… then when the Sun went out, wouldn’t there have been a lot of people who…”

“Not many people could have really seen that scene,” Duncan slowly shook his head. “When the Sun went out, we also looked up at the sky. All we saw was a sphere that had fallen completely into darkness. You could not see any details with the naked eye. This drawing shows the same thing. That eyeball is ‘sealed’ inside a huge container.

“At the time, Taran Ael used a special observation device from the Truth Academy to see what the inside of that sphere really looked like. You don’t have to worry that ordinary people elsewhere might casually glimpse this madness-inducing ‘truth’.”

Hearing this, Goathead seemed to breathe a sigh of relief. But right after that, he started worrying again: “Not many, but there still could be some… Not everyone reacts like Taran Ael. Not everyone can seal and alter their own notes by instinct while in a mental runaway state. And judging by what Taran Ael did afterward, anyone who sees this eyeball seems unable to stop themselves from wanting to spread its image…”

Duncan listened to Goathead’s anxious muttering without saying anything. His face stayed calm and dark as water. He seemed to be deep in thought.

Goathead nagged for quite a while. When he saw that the captain did not react at all, he finally could not help but remind him: “Captain, do you think

we should maybe warn…”

“Pland and Frostholm don’t have anything like that observation device. That lens array belongs to the Truth Academy. It is precise and rare,” Duncan finally raised his head. “Outside of Lightwind Harbor, even if someone tried to observe the surface of Vision 001 while the Sun was out, they would still not see these ‘truths’.”

“Pland and Frostholm don’t, but other city-states might!” Goathead shouted at once. “Who knows what those reckless fools might do! Mortals are not a reliable race!”

“…Other city-states never saw that extinguished Sun,” Duncan suddenly said.

Goathead, who had been working himself up, went quiet in an instant.

“Have you forgotten?” Duncan reminded him calmly. “Only three city-states and the ‘Vanished Fleet’ saw the world where the Sun went out. The rest of the whole Boundless Sea did not go through those twelve hours of darkness at all.”

Goathead’s head swayed left and right a little, then he finally let out a confused little sigh: “Oh… er…”

Duncan did not say anything more. He simply lowered his head again to look at the sketch that showed the core structure of Vision 001. As he did, another scene slowly rose up in his mind.

A blazing, splendid corona. Below the corona, twisted, coiled limbs of flesh. And a dying giant eyeball, held up by countless pale, fleshy limbs.

The Crawling Sun Wheel – the Black Sun.

Duncan’s brows tightened bit by bit. Once that faint sense of familiarity appeared, it could no longer be ignored. The memory in his mind quickly

overlapped with the sketch on the paper. Bold ideas started to rise one after another in his heart.

“…It looks a lot like the true Sun god’s eye.” He suddenly whispered to himself.

“Ah?” Goathead jumped at once. “What terrible thing are you talking about?!”

“This eyeball looks very much like part of the ‘Crawling Sun Wheel’s’ structure,” Duncan said slowly, his expression thoughtful. As the details in his memory filled in, his judgment became more and more certain. “Yes. Very much so. If you take this ‘eyeball’ out and look at it alone, it is almost exactly the same.”

With a sharp little crack, Goathead’s neck seemed to jam at a certain angle. He went completely stiff on the enchanted sea chart table and fell silent.

Even a chatterbox like him had, for the first time, nothing at all to say.

Duncan let out a slow breath. Then he folded the draft carefully and tucked it away close to his body.

Luckily, Lucretia had been cautious enough not to leave this sheet with the ordinary scholars of the Truth Academy. He truly had no idea what kind of disaster that might have caused. Even though the Truth Academy did not have his convenient “spirit form flame” to remove the seal on the page, they still had all kinds of strange research methods. It was very possible that they could have restored the true image on that draft in the end.

Just then, hurried footsteps sounded outside the captain’s cabin and broke Duncan’s thoughts. A knock followed, and Morris’s voice came from outside: “Captain, I have something to report to you!”

Duncan quickly adjusted his expression and looked toward the door: “Come in.”

The door of the captain’s cabin opened. Morris walked in quickly and, as he walked, took a letter from inside his coat: “Captain, Heidi suddenly sent a letter. She mentioned… something unusual in it, and I need to report it to you.”

A letter from Heidi?

Duncan paused for a moment, then reached out to take the letter. He had not expected that, so soon after they had built their link and he had told her the truth, that Miss Psychiatrist would contact them again. At the same time, he felt puzzled: “Why didn’t she just come to the antique shop to find me? Why did she send the letter to you instead?”

Ai traveled between the Vanished and Pland every day. Besides carrying necessary supplies, she also did routine mail pickup and delivery at places like the Cathedral, Morris’s house, and the Governor’s residence. So it was normal for Heidi to send a letter through those channels. But if she wanted to contact the captain of the Vanished, then going straight to the antique shop would clearly have been the easier option.

“…She is still a bit nervous and afraid,” Morris explained with a slightly awkward tone. “After learning the truth, she probably doesn’t dare meet your avatar form directly.”

“…That nervousness is unnecessary. Just last week she came to my shop and bought a vase,” Duncan muttered. He casually opened the letter, ran his eyes over the lines of words written in obvious haste, and his gaze suddenly changed a little.

In the next moment, Duncan put away his relaxed expression. His face turned serious, then gradually grew heavy. He quickly read through the rest of the letter, then stayed silent for a few seconds before raising his head to look at Morris: “She ran into a Ender…”

“Yes. And according to her description, it seems to have been one of the rational ones,” Morris nodded. “Though that uninvited guest’s ‘rationality’ is suspicious. He muttered nonsense from start to finish and never explained anything clearly…”

Clearly, this old mister, who had spent his life teaching many students and always believed that “knowledge should be explained simply, directly, and clearly”, was very unhappy with this riddle-speaking cultist mentioned in the letter. There was a lot of resentment in his tone.

“Not speaking clearly might be because of some kind of restriction. What matters is that he was willing to talk. That is the main difference between the two kinds of Ender,” Duncan said quickly. Then he lowered his head again to glance at the letter. The various bits of information described there flowed into his eyes.

The fourth Long Night… the Promised Ark… the Sun becoming ‘gentle’, the coming of dusk, and… “holes” that appeared with some kind of “variable” and kept growing…

Heidi had tried her best to record in the letter exactly what she had heard from that Ender, all his strange, rambling claims. She had not added any “extra work” based on her own guesses.

These messages alone were enough to fill Duncan’s mind with countless guesses and connections.

“That Ender did not seem very clear-headed. And he appeared in the daytime instead of at night like other ‘normal’ preachers,” Morris said from the side. “He talked about the fourth Long Night and also about many ‘signs’ that would appear before it began. It seems that the very fact he could appear in the daytime was itself a ‘harbinger’ that this so-called fourth Long Night is about to begin…”

The fourth Long Night…

In Duncan’s mind, the description he had read in “The Blasphemous Tome” surfaced on its own:

There had been three Genesis Protocols, and they were the “three Long Nights”. The king of the pale giants had died in the first Long Night. The King of Dreams had died in the second. During the third Long Night, the Crawling King had finally succeeded in shaping all things. Together with the Critt clan, He lit the Sun that now shone over the world, ending the veil of night. Yet He Himself, because He had changed the Blueprint without permission, had been exiled by the other ancient Elder Kings and could never return to the throne…

Duncan slowly rose from behind the chart table and walked to the window.

The Sun was about to sink below the sea’s horizon.

Bound by magnificent double rune rings, the bright and warm orb slowly sank into the sea. Its afterglow washed the waves in gold.

Duncan gazed at it with his gaze and imagined that he was actually looking at a giant eyeball, larger than any city-state, that had been watching this world for ten thousand years.

This “eye”, which had risen into the sky in the age of the ancient Critt kingdom, had now grown old and weak.

The Veil of warm, peaceful light that it had woven seemed about to fall with the Sun’s death. After this Veil vanished, after the “fourth Long Night” that the Ender had described really arrived… what would this world’s “dusk” look like?

Chapter 545: Alice’s New Friend

On the foredeck of the Radiant Star, Shirley clung to the rail at the ship’s side. Her face shone with excitement as she watched the coastline grow clearer on the distant horizon. She shouted happily: “Oh, oh, oh! I see the harbor! I can already see the harbor!”

“Don’t get so excited you fall overboard,” Dog’s voice came from beside her. “And don’t just stand there laughing like a fool. Don’t forget what you promised the captain before we left. Even if you’re going out to play, you still…”

Shirley started waving her hands before he even finished: “Yeah, yeah, I know, I know. Dog, you’re so naggy. Why do you sound like some old auntie…”

The Abyssal Hound lying on the deck beside her grew unhappy at once and began a new round of nagging. Not far away, Lucretia watched the scene on the deck with a subtle, complicated look. Her eyes flickered, and no one could tell what she was thinking.

Nina stood beside Lucretia. She watched this “sea witch”, who had an elegant, mysterious air and a beautiful face that still carried a cold, unsettling distance, and spoke in a small, nervous voice: “You don’t think Shirley is too noisy, do you? She’s always like this…”

“No.” Lucretia turned her head a little and answered softly. “This ship is always noisy. My dolls can make a much bigger ruckus than this.”

“Oh…” Nina let out a small “oh”, then smiled a bit shyly. “Um… thank you for letting us ride on this ship.”

“Father asked me to take you all to Lightwind Harbor, so of course I will do it,” Lucretia said. She glanced at Nina. She seemed not very used to dealing with strangers. To others, that unease and awkwardness often looked like coldness and pride, so she worked to adjust her expression and make herself look a bit warmer. “I remember your name is Nina, right?”

“Yes.” Nina nodded at once. A bright smile spread over her face.

“…You call my Father ‘Uncle Duncan’,” Lucretia said, with a hint of curiosity in her eyes. “You… aren’t you afraid?”

“I’m not. Uncle Duncan is very kind,” Nina said with a smile. Then she paused. Her bright smile faded into a gentle one, and she looked into the eyes of this “witch” miss in front of her. “I know what happened. You don’t need to worry… and I think things are very good as they are now.”

“…That’s good, then.” Lucretia quietly looked at Nina for a while and gave a small nod.

But right after that, she heard this girl named Nina ask another curious question: “Lucretia… um… are you and Uncle Duncan not on very good terms?”

“Why do you ask that?”

“I heard someone say so. They said the Radiant Star broke with the Vanished a century ago. And just now, when Uncle Duncan was bringing us over here, I saw you always seemed to avoid his eyes on purpose,” Nina said. Her voice grew softer and softer. “Sorry… Did I say something wrong? That sounded kind of rude…”

“We did walk down different paths in the past,” Lucretia said. She did not seem bothered. She only shook her head. “But that is all old history. As for

now, I don’t know if my relationship with Father can be called good or bad. I think… we have just gone too long without seeing each other.”

Nina blinked as she listened. She seemed to hear the faint regret and sadness in the “witch” miss’s voice. After a small hesitation, Nina said: “You’re not like what I imagined at first… Before I met you in person, I was actually very nervous.”

“People always make wild guesses about things they don’t understand, and they never feel responsible for those guesses,” Lucretia said with a small smile. “Also, Nina, you don’t have to use honorifics when you call me. You can just use my name.”

Nina froze for a moment: “But you…”

“My Father is your ‘Uncle Duncan’,” Lucretia said, looking at Nina. At last, there was some real warmth in her smile. “If you keep using honorifics in that situation, I’m going to feel really awkward.”

Nina thought about it and nodded: “Oh, that does make sense…”

The corners of Lucretia’s mouth lifted. She looked at this young lady who was, in essence, a fragment of the Sun, yet in words and actions was just an ordinary girl. Then she turned her head to glance at the “demon summoner” lying over the rail not far away, who could not wait to go exploring in the city.

At the same time, that Grand Scholar Morris was in the cabin, catching up with Taran Ael, whom he had not seen in decades. The two of them seemed to be planning a visit to Lightwind Harbor’s city-state university. The “exiled Inquisitor” named Vanna was midway down the deck, following the rabbit Rabby and curiously touring the ship’s unique “spirit form structure”.

As for the living doll named “Alice”, she was surely still with Father right now. As soon as Father had come aboard, he had said he wanted to

introduce her to Lunie and then had left with her.

They were Father's new "followers". While countless clever people in the world were exhausting themselves trying to guess the goal behind the Vanished Fleet's reformation, these people looked as if they were here on vacation.

In one sense, they were indeed very strong. Each of them had their own special skills and was more than worthy of a place in the Vanished Fleet. But in another sense…

They were completely different from what Lucretia had first imagined.

They were not a terrifying, suffocating group of "Subspace retainers". On the contrary, they were interesting, and it was easy and pleasant to be around them. Father had gathered these people together… and it did not feel like some deep, far-reaching plan. It felt more like he had just happened to gather some traveling companions.

"After we dock, I'll arrange a place for you to stay," Lucretia said, drawing in her drifting thoughts. "I have a few bases in Lightwind Harbor, and they are kept fairly clean. Do you have any plans once you go into the city? I can give you some suggestions."

"Suggestions?" Nina's eyes lit up at once. "Then do you… I mean, do you know where in Lightwind Harbor there is the most good food? I heard this city-state has the largest variety of food in the whole Boundless Sea, and I came here for that!"

Lucretia's expression turned odd for a moment: "…The 'food' in Lightwind Harbor?"

Nina nodded hard: "Yes!"

"…Father never explained elven food culture to you in detail?"

“No,” Nina said blankly. She seemed to faintly sense something strange in Lucretia’s tone. “Um, did I get something wrong?”

“…You’re not exactly wrong. It’s just something you have to experience for yourself,” Lucretia said after thinking a bit, her face serious. “I’ll take you to the Crown District later.”

Nina looked full of hope: “Is there a lot of good food there?”

“…It’s near the hospital.”

Nina: “…?”

At the same time, in the crew rest area of the Radiant Star, Duncan had found himself a seat. He leaned back to rest while watching an interesting scene not far away.

Two dolls stood there, both looking a bit blank.

Alice studied the stranger in front of her, who looked even more “doll-like” than she did. After thinking for a long time, she suddenly turned her head: “Captain! How do you make friends with strangers?”

“Start by introducing yourself,” Duncan said. No one knew where he had gotten a few fries, but he tossed them toward Ai, who was strolling lazily across a small table nearby. “Begin with your name.”

“Oh.” Alice nodded, then turned back to the doll standing across from her. “Hello, my name is Alice. I’m also called Anomaly 099.”

“Hello, I’m Lunie,” the clockwork doll facing Alice bent at the waist as well and introduced herself with great politeness. “I am Mistress Lucretia’s servant. Are you Old Master’s servant?”

“I’m not. I’m the captain’s doll! On the ship I’m in charge of cooking and cleaning!”

Lunie tilted her head. Somewhere in her body, gears gave a soft scraping sound.

Alice kept looking curiously at her new friend: “You don’t have any strings on your head!”

“Strings? What are those?”

“They’re things everyone has. They float out of their bodies. The captain says only I can see them,” Alice said, waving her hands as she talked. “He says they might be ‘Soul Threads’. I don’t really understand what that means, but whenever I grab one, the person stops moving…”

“It’s hard to understand what you’re saying,” Lunie answered in a slightly stiff tone. “I am a doll. I don’t have a soul… but I do have a spring.”

As she spoke, the clockwork doll turned around and showed Alice the winding handle at her lower back, shaped like a big bow.

“Oh, a spring. I have one too!” Alice said at once, delighted. She turned around as well to show her new friend. “See this spot? There’s also a keyhole under my clothes, but I can’t reach it myself, so the key is in the captain’s hands…”

“Interesting. We have something in common,” Lunie said. A lively series of gear sounds came from inside her, as if she was happy. “This is the first time I’ve seen someone similar to myself. Mistress and Old Master both said you could become my friend. It seems they were right.”

“Right? The captain is amazing!” Alice said joyfully. “And look, our joints are very similar too, even though your arms are a bit stiffer than mine…”

Lunie lowered her head and looked at her own arm. “Yes. We have similar joint structures.”

Alice became even happier. She suddenly cupped her own head in her hands. “Oh, right. Can your head come off? Mine can! Look—”

With a little “pop”, Alice pulled off her own head right in front of Lunie. She held it up in both hands and showed it off: “See, see, see, I can take it off…”

Lunie stared in wonder at this amazing move from her new friend. Then she lifted her own hands, cupped her head, and gave a pull.

Clack.

Chapter 546:

Lucretia stared in silence at the clockwork doll lying on the lab table. Alice stood on the other side of the table, looking tense and uneasy, while Duncan stood beside Alice, his face blank.

After the awkward mood had dragged on for a long time, Lucretia finally broke the silence: “…So Lunie took her own head off?”

“…The process was complicated,” Duncan said stiffly. “I was surprised too.”

Lucretia could not help glancing at Duncan.

She did not know if it was just her imagination, but she felt that on the always grim, always gloomy face of her Father, there had been a trace of… embarrassment just now.

“I’m sorry…” Alice finally spoke. She lowered her head and carefully pinched the hem of Duncan’s coat, clearly aware she had caused trouble again. “I saw Lunie is also a doll, so I thought dolls are all the same, and… I was surprised her head isn’t actually removable?”

“…It seems Lunie also thought she was the same as you,” Lucretia said, giving a complicated look at this “Anomaly 099” who had once made countless people tremble in fear. “But I never designed that ‘feature’ for her.”

Just then, Lunie’s separated head on the lab table suddenly moved. Her head blinked, and her voice sounded a little off-key: “Mistress, could you

connect my head first? I’m sorry for causing you trouble…”

Lucretia looked down at the clockwork doll’s head with a blank face, sighed, picked up a tool from the side, and began removing the cover plates and decorative pieces around Lunie’s neck. As she worked, she could not help asking: “Why did you follow Alice without even thinking?”

“Alice… is a new friend,” Lunie’s head said from the side. Her mouth opened and closed with a faint crackling noise. “A new friend brought by Old Master.”

Lucretia’s hands paused for a moment. Then she said nothing more and kept working.

Alice watched Lunie’s head a little nervously: “Then are we still friends from now on?”

“We can be,” Lunie blinked. “But we have to wait until Mistress fixes me…”

Alice brightened at once, then suddenly seemed to notice something shocking: “Ah, when your head is off, you don’t stutter anymore when you talk!”

“Yes. Because my head can operate on its own. Mistress installed a complete vocal system in my skull, and my thoughts are not affected by the loss of my body,” Lunie explained in a serious tone. “The difference between you and me is that once my neck breaks, I cannot recover on my own.”

Alice thought about it. She did not really understand, but she still nodded: “Oh—so amazing.”

Duncan watched from the side, feeling that this scene had already become as bizarre as it could possibly get.

More uncanny than a cursed Doll whose head could fall off was, indeed, giving that doll another doll as a friend. He had not even introduced Alice to the other strange “servants” on this ship yet.

If this big goof wandered all over the Radiant Star, how chaotic would the ship become?

As Lucretia bent over Lunie’s joints, busy with disassembly and repair, she suddenly felt a jolt in her heart. She lifted her head in confusion and looked around but could not find the source of that sudden chill.

Soon, though, her attention moved on to other matters.

“About that ‘eyeball’ recorded by Captain Taran Ael—what do you think of it?” The “Sea Witch” turned and looked at Duncan. “We definitely can’t make this public to ordinary people, but as for the Four Gods Church…”

“I do plan to tell them, but I still haven’t decided which channel to use, or whether I need to make more direct contact with their high ranks,” Duncan said, quickly gathering his scattered thoughts. His expression grew serious. “Right now the key isn’t that ‘the true body of Vision 001 is an eyeball sealed inside an artificial sphere’. Since history began, Vision 001 has been unknown to mortals anyway, so its real form could be as strange and terrifying as you like. What really matters is what that eyeball looks like.”

“The way that eyeball looks…” Lucretia’s hands slowed, and her brows drew together a little. “You said it looks very similar to… some structure of the Creeping Sun Wheel?”

“The true body of the Creeping Sun Wheel is an Elder God wrapped and scorched by a corona. Among the layers and layers of its tentacles, a huge eyeball structure is its main feature,” Duncan said with a nod. “That eye left a deep impression on me—it stared at me for a very long time.”

Listening to Father, Lucretia suddenly looked around uneasily, then glanced back at Duncan with some hesitation: “Talking about the Elder Gods so directly while we’re at sea…”

“It’s not a big problem. Even if that thing’s ‘gaze’ really gets drawn here, it will only fall on me,” Duncan waved his hand. “And I’ve been wanting to find it anyway.”

Lucretia opened her mouth, but for a moment she did not know how to answer.

In this past century, she had roamed the Boundless Sea and seen many things. She had dealt with many Madmen and had taken part in more than a few forbidden and dangerous events. But even those taboo topics were not usually discussed in such a blunt, casual way.

She felt she might really need a long time to relearn how to get along with the Father of today.

Duncan did not notice Lucretia’s brief, complicated expression. After a short silence, he thought of something else: “Do you still remember the ‘intruder’ that appeared in Captain Taran Ael’s dream? That projection of the Sun Spawn.”

“I remember. You said it looked like a smaller version of the Creeping Sun Wheel,” Lucretia said with a nod. “You also said that Sun Spawn had a short conversation with you, and that it and its minions were searching for something in that dream.”

Duncan nodded slightly, then spoke slowly: “The core of Vision 001 is an eyeball that is extremely similar to the core of the Creeping Sun Wheel. Twelve hours after Vision 001 went out, the Sun Spawn used Captain Taran Ael’s Dream Invasion to enter the Nameless One’s dream and searched that dream with its minions. Those two events are clearly linked.

“On the other hand, for thousands of years the Black Sun believers have claimed that the god they worship is the ‘true Sun’ and have called the Sun in the sky the ‘false sun’. People always thought this was only their mad delusion, caused by the Black Sun’s spiritual corruption twisting those believers’ view of the world. Yet when the Sun went out, Captain Taran Ael found that there really is an eyeball sealed inside Vision 001, one that is extremely similar to the core structure of the Creeping Sun Wheel.

“Lastly, there is that cultist of Annihilation who invaded the Nameless One’s dream. According to the information I’ve gathered, the goal of the Cult of Annihilation is not the same as the Suntists’. In that dream, they were searching for ‘the first blueprint from before the Holy Lord created the world’. But according to The Blasphemous Tome, during the Genesis Protocol of the Abyssal Lord, that Lord once guided the Critt clan, and may even have personally helped them build Vision 001. So strictly speaking, the current Vision 001—the ‘false sun’ in the mouths of the Suntists—can also be seen as the Abyssal Lord’s ‘masterpiece’, a part of the original blueprint.

“This last point may also explain the ‘cooperative state’ I observed between the Cult of Annihilation and the Sun cult. They are indeed cooperating, but it’s obvious their relationship is not a friendly one.”

Duncan slowly laid out the thoughts he had been turning over in his mind these days. Then he lifted his eyes and looked into Lucretia’s.

“From all this information, what comes to your mind?”

Without noticing it, Lucretia had already stopped moving. Her expression shifted several times, heavy and uneasy at once. After a long pause, she finally broke the silence in a low voice: “…Even if a cultist who worships the Black Sun were standing here, I think they would say this is a bit extreme…”

“…I heard something similar not long ago,” Duncan shook his head. “Now I only hope that the truth in the deep layers of our world isn’t more insane than this. Otherwise, compared to real history, even the most extreme cultists will seem conservative.”

Lucretia said nothing. She only lowered her gaze slowly, sinking into thought.

Lunie’s head still lay on the lab table, her eyes meeting the Mistress’s thoughtful stare.

After a while, Lunie finally could not hold back: “Mistress… are you still fixing me? Maybe you should go next door to rest for a bit? You could let Rabby come help…”

Lucretia let out a breath and pushed aside the stray thoughts in her mind. She picked up her tools and got back to work: “Rabby would only stuff your head into its own belly to ease its endless hunger for ‘cotton’. Don’t move. I’m putting your head back on.”

“Oh.”

…

At the same time, in the governor’s office of Lightwind Harbor, Governor Sara Mell unfolded a document that had just been delivered to her desk. As she read its contents, this Elf who had already lived for a very long time slowly furrowed her brows.

The document came from the Four Gods Church. It was not issued by any single Church, but carried the seals of all four Popes, witnessed by the Four Gods, and had been sent to every city-state on the Boundless Sea.

It ordered the creation of an early warning system jointly built by the city-states, the Church, and the Explorer associations, to monitor any anomalies that might appear in the city-states, on the sea, or under the sea, to guard

against a repeat of the Frostholm crisis and to guard against the Elder Gods waking.

The Four Gods Church would also pull part of its patrol fleets back from the borders into the inner regions of the civilized world, so they could respond at any time to emergencies across the world.

These two points were worrying, but still normal enough. At least for the rulers of the city-states, they could still be understood as “work duties”.

What really made Governor Sara Mell frown was the final line of the document. It seemed to be mentioned casually, yet it stood out as especially important—

“All city-states must take seriously any warning signals from the Vanished or from the Vanished Fleet. If the main vessel of the Vanished is found operating in the waters near a city-state… you must not take any hostile action, and should… cooperate as needed.”

Chapter 547:

On Crown Street, in a neighborhood at the edge of Lightwind Harbor’s Upper City, there was a mansion wrapped in mystery, standing at the very end of the street—No. 99 Crown Street.

It was a three?story, steep?roofed building with a clear northern city-state style, completely different from the Elf-style houses common in Lightwind Harbor. It had a dark roof that sharply contrasted with its white outer walls, and tall windows with intricate carvings and solemn lines. Wide gardens spread out in front of and behind the house—quite rare in the city-state—filled with all sorts of strange flowers and bushes that almost no one could name.

Many people knew this mansion existed, but almost no one knew anything about it. Its master almost never showed herself. On normal days only a few quiet, tight?lipped servants tended the garden and the house. After nightfall, when lights came on inside, eerie and frightening shadows would appear in those lit windows—

Some people firmly claimed they had seen those servants, who tended the house in the day, take off their human skins at night and turn into creaking puppets and tin men that walked back and forth through the rooms. Some said that when they passed near the mansion, strange whispers lured them away, and when they snapped out of it, they had somehow appeared somewhere else. Some even swore they had seen the flowers and plants in the front yard turn into pitch?black thorns at the very moment the Sun set, wrapping the entire first floor of the house like a cage.

Strange rumors spread from all this, too many to count. In the wildest stories, busybodies claimed that a Lady's vengeful spirit was imprisoned inside the house, that the power of a curse seeped up from the basement and transformed the original servants—when night came, it turned them into tin men and puppets with no mind or memory.

In the end, though, these tales all proved to be nothing more than the nervous fantasies of passersby. In city-states on the Boundless Sea, there were always plenty of such rumors and wild guesses.

The changes and corruption brought by the veil of night kept everyone on edge. Many people, in their excessive vigilance, treated every whistling cave and every empty house with strange noises as a nest of filth growing in the dark. The Guardians of the city-states dealt with many reports involving the supernatural every day, and there were bound to be some such nervous "false alarms" among them. In general, as long as this tension did not cross the line into "spiritual corruption", it was not a real problem.

After all, simple nervousness was not enough to actually "create" something in the dark. It was better for citizens to have enough caution than to stay numb when real supernatural contamination began.

As for the mansion's true master…

The Sea Witch had long grown used to the fearful looks and horrible rumors that followed her. In fact, to some extent, part of the rumors around No. 99 Crown Street had been spread by her on purpose.

"I needed a place in the city-state to rest. Always staying at sea would strain anyone's nerves. I'm no exception," Lucretia said. After returning to her 'home' in Lightwind Harbor, she walked to the window and looked at the quiet door outside. "But I don't like dealing with people. It's hard to find a place in a city-state where no one bothers you. Even the most remote streets

are crowded. So I might as well make a bit of scary noise, so people won't stand at my door staring out of curiosity."

"Why not try learning from Tyrian?" Duncan was curiously studying the furnishings in the big house. When he heard Lucretia, he spoke casually: "He picked an uninhabited island in the Frost Sea to serve as a base for the Sea Mist Fleet. He hasn't had to worry about being disturbed for a whole century…"

Lucretia turned her head: "And then get caught by you, Dad, while secretly watching strip shows at home?"

Duncan coughed twice at once: "Ahem, don't talk about your brother like that—say it to his face next time."

Lucretia: "…"

The Witch's eye twitched. She herself did not even know whether she liked Father's current personality, but she knew she clearly needed some time to get used to it.

Soon she smoothed her expression and said: "I can't copy him. Taking an island means building and managing countless facilities, commanding a whole fleet, and maintaining an entire system from logistics to external dealings. I don't have the mind for that—it would eat up a huge amount of the time I use for research. Just keeping the Radiant Star running already uses up all my energy."

Footsteps came from the side. A servant in a black?and?white uniform walked over with a tray. On the tray lay warmed towels and cool drinks to ease the weariness of travel. The servant bowed slightly to Lucretia and Duncan. A stiff, corpse?like smile was frozen on its face, and the ticking of clockwork gears came faintly from inside its body.

“You and Tyrian each have your own field of talent,” Duncan said. He took a glass from the tray and, still curious, looked over this “footman” that was almost no different from a real person, yet, if you stared a bit longer, clearly felt wrong enough to stir fear. “Before I met you again, I heard many rumors about you. Those rumors said you siblings were cold to each other, almost hostile. Now that I see it, those tales were wildly off.”

“After all… the split of the Vanished Fleet was a major event a century ago, and what happened after that isn’t something ordinary people can find out,” Lucretia said, shaking her head with a complicated look. “They only know that the Radiant Star and the Sea Mist went their separate ways, almost to opposite ends of the civilized world. So of course they imagine… a whole big drama.”

As she spoke, Lucretia gave a small, helpless shake of her head.

“After you… left, my brother and I met a few times for short visits. By then the Vanished had completely disappeared from the Mortal Realm, but we could still feel that you were… ‘alive’.”

She looked out the window, speaking softly, as if to herself, about things no outsider could ever know.

“Near the borders, at nightfall, on the routes you once explored, as soon as our minds relaxed a little, we would ‘hear’ your voice. Mindless roars, full of malice and a desire to destroy, came again and again from the depths of the world, as if struggling to rise and tear open the barrier between the Mortal Realm and the Subspace…

“Several times we even saw you and the Vanished in the dim light between day and night. That ship rose from the darkness and closed in on us like Doomsday itself. Wherever it passed, there was only death.

“Later we found that only we could see that scene. It existed only in our sight and in our thoughts.

“After that, my brother summed up some patterns. He discovered that it was exactly because of ‘us’ that your ‘gaze’ was drawn here. The closer Tyrian and I were to each other, the stronger that pull became… Do you know? It was like lamps. Two lamps together shine brighter, and Tyrian and I were the ‘lighthouse’ for you to return from the Subspace to the Mortal Realm…

“So we split up, farther and farther. Tyrian went to the northern border, and I kept sailing south. When we were half a world apart, we finally stopped seeing your phantom. When we went even farther… we finally stopped hearing your roar.”

Lucretia let out a soft breath, as if a heavy weight had dropped from her shoulders. Those words had been held in for a century and had finally come out in one long rush.

Duncan listened quietly at her side, not knowing what to say. He knew that the “Witch” was really mourning and speaking about another person. He did not have to feel any burden from her story, did not have to feel regret or guilt. Yet for some reason, he found it hard to remain unmoved. Feelings rose in his heart that he was not sure even belonged to him. After a long silence, he could only give a quiet sigh: “You two have had a hard time.”

“Honestly… it wasn’t that bad,” Lucretia said with a small smile, shaking her head. “In the first ten years, we missed you very much. Hearing those voices and seeing those visions even made us think unrealistic thoughts. We wondered if, when you followed the ‘light’ back to the Mortal Realm, maybe everything could still be fixed.

“In the next ten years, the terrible disasters caused by the Vanished drawing near the Mortal Realm again and again grew more and more common. We began to feel afraid. Along with a feeling that may or may not count as

‘responsibility’, my brother and I started looking for a way to truly and completely banish you.

“A few years later, our ‘banishment’ seemed to start working. As fear faded, longing kept rising again. My brother would sometimes bring up the old days. We were very careful not to mention your name or the Vanished, yet we could not stop ourselves from talking about those great routes and those unforgettable voyages…

“By the most recent thirty or forty years, we had already gone through everything we could talk about. We slowly stopped bringing up the Vanished at all. It felt as if everything had finally passed. In most city-states’ official documents and in the captains’ sailing records, the Vanished had become just a ‘historical term’, a legend. Along with that, people’s fear of the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star seemed to fade a lot.

“And then you appeared. The White Oak fled from the storm and brought terrible news to the city-state of Pland… Did you know? Tyrian didn’t sleep well for three whole days after he got that news.”

She suddenly laughed. It seemed she had not laughed this freely in a hundred years.

At the ends of her hair, the silver?white ornament shaped like waves and feathers swayed with her smile, shining with warm light.

Duncan let out a soft sigh.

But just as he was about to speak, a scream suddenly rang out from the direction of the living room, cutting off his conversation with Lucretia.

It sounded like Nina’s voice.

Duncan and Lucretia quickly exchanged a look, then turned and ran toward the living room.

Halfway there, they heard Nina’s voice, full of shock and anger—

“Why! Would they! Put stinky beans! On pancakes-”

Chapter 548: Food Customs

Nina had looked forward to the trip to Lightwind Harbor for a long time, and she had looked forward to the food of the Elven city-state for just as long.

Now she finally faced the cruel reality of the Mortal Realm.

She sat blank-eyed at the table, staring at the dark heap in front of her.

It was a stack of overbaked pancakes, piled high with some kind of fermented beans that stretched into strings and bubbled.

Even without tasting it, she could imagine how shocking the flavor must be.

This had already gone beyond Nina's idea of "food". It looked more like some kind of abstract artwork.

Shirley, sitting across from her, was clearly not doing much better.

In front of Shirley lay the "locally improved Elven version" of sweet crepes. The smell from the fermented cheese on top was so strong that her face had gone a little green.

After a long time, Shirley finally lifted her head, looked at Nina across the table, then raised a hand to point at the food: "They said this thing is sweet crepes…"

"How can they insult sweet crepes like this…" Nina looked as if she was about to cry. "This has been my favorite food since I was little…"

“But this really is Lightwind Harbor’s sweet crepes,” said Taran Ael, who sat at the other end of the table.

This Grand Scholar, who was quite famous even in Truth Academy, actually looked a little nervous and uneasy.

No one knew if it was because he felt he was neglecting Captain Duncan’s Retainer, or because he simply could not face the almost resentful gazes of the two girls.

“As far as I know, many outsiders really can’t get used to it at first… but some people like it very much once they do.”

Nina stared at him in horror: “But these beans are rotten! Not just rotten, they even stretch into strings! The slime is bubbling!”

“But they taste very good, truly,” Taran Ael tried his best to explain sincerely. “And there is absolutely no problem with health—on the contrary, they are very good for the digestive system…”

Nina and Shirley listened to the Grand Scholar’s explanation with expressions like their souls had left their bodies.

It seemed their minds could no longer keep up with the logic of the Mortal Realm.

When Duncan arrived, this was exactly the scene he saw—just as he had expected.

He could not help laughing. He walked forward and rubbed Nina’s hair: “I told you before. You might not be able to get used to the food in Lightwind Harbor. The Elves changed many local specialties to fit their own tastes.”

Nina muttered under her breath: “I just couldn’t imagine what they would change them into…”

“I did not think this through,” Taran Ael said at once.

The moment he saw Duncan appear he had tensed up on reflex, but after traveling with them this far he had at least learned how to adjust himself.

He quickly calmed down and spoke apologetically to the two very disappointed girls: “I should have recommended some foods that are not quite so ‘local’ first.

“The bread and smoked meat rolls in Lightwind Harbor are the same as anywhere else.

“We can just put these things aside.”

But to everyone’s surprise, as soon as Taran Ael said that, Shirley suddenly pressed her lips together and picked up the strange-smelling “crepe” in front of her.

Lucretia, who had been watching the fun from the side, blinked in surprise: “Shirley?”

“It’s food,” Shirley muttered.

Then, as if making a huge decision, she shut her eyes and shoved the crepe into her mouth.

She chewed hard, speaking in a muffled voice:

“It’s… not that bad…”

Nina stared at her friend across the table in shock.

After a moment, she seemed to think of something.

Then, without a word, she picked up the things on her own plate.

The two girls almost wolfed down all the food that Taran Ael had bought.

Then they wiped their mouths at almost the same time, lifted their heads, looked at each other, and broke into matching grins.

The living room suddenly went a bit quiet.

Duncan smiled, patted Nina on the shoulder, then walked over and wiped the “sauce” off Shirley’s face.

Taran Ael, after staring blankly for a few seconds, finally reacted.

With a trace of awkwardness, he broke the silence:

“Very few outsiders can adapt to these dishes so quickly…

“Oh, by the way, if you are not used to the fermented foods here in Lightwind Harbor, we do have many dishes that keep the flavor of their place of origin.

“Besides the bread and smoked meat rolls I just mentioned, there are Central Seas–style cream stews, lanjing-grass braised meat, northern mushroom stew, and red-vegetable egg custard…”

As Nina listened, her eyes went wide, and a bit of hopeful light returned to them: “So you do have food that tastes normal?! Why didn’t you say so earlier!”

Taran Ael spread his hands:

“Because it is not time for dessert yet.”

Nina’s face, which had just brightened, went dull again:

“…Dessert?”

“Yes,” Taran Ael nodded. “What I just listed are all desserts.

“We usually mash them into a paste and use them as a dip for honey cakes.”

This time, not only Nina, but even Duncan was deeply shocked.

Across the table, Shirley instantly grabbed her head and groaned weakly: “Damn it, I want to go back to the ship… What kind of Subspace execution

ground is this…”

Duncan thought for a moment.

[Even in Subspace, no one eats things like this.]

But with Taran Ael, a native Elf of this city-state, standing right there, he did not say it aloud.

Just then, a burst of electric bell chimes rang from the direction of the front door, suddenly cutting off the talk in the living room.

Lucretia frowned, almost too slightly to notice.

A “footman” in a servant’s uniform stepped out of the living room with stiff, mechanical strides.

A moment later, the male servant returned from the entrance hall, walked up to his Mistress, and bowed slightly: “A Visitor from City Hall. Governor Sara Mell invites you to come discuss affairs.”

Lucretia frowned, impatience showing in her face:

“Tell him I am not going. I am entertaining more important guests and have no time.”

“But the messenger said that what Governor Sara Mell wishes to discuss is directly related to your ‘honored guests’,” the footman said in the same mechanical, wooden tone. “And there is also the witness of the Four Gods in this matter.”

Lucretia’s expression finally changed a little.

She lifted her head on reflex and glanced at Duncan.

Duncan had of course heard the exchange between her and the footman, but he looked quite unconcerned.

He simply waved a hand:

“It is normal. I walked into the city right beside you, in full view.

“Other city-states might not care, but in an Elven city-state, someone like me—a ‘Adventurer’ who was still active a hundred years ago—is hardly a stranger’s face.”

“Then he should come in person,” Lucretia said, her tone holding some displeasure. “Sending someone over so casually is not proper courtesy.”

“Think about Tyrian’s schedule right now. A city-state’s Governor is not that free,” Duncan said with a small laugh.

He gave a glance at the “Sea Witch” who looked cold and arrogant on the surface, but who in truth only refused to go out because she hated trouble and was lazy.

“Go out this once. Hear what the Governor has to say.

“I am quite curious too, about how he managed to drag in the ‘witness of the Four Gods’.

“Or I could go with you?”

“Ah, I can go by myself!” Lucretia said quickly.

Then she sighed, nodded a farewell to the others in the living room, and turned to leave.

Two or three pieces of colored paper fluttered out from beside her, but in the next second, they all flew back into her body.

Lucretia suddenly stopped, turned her head with a strange look to glance at Duncan, forced out a stiff smile, and then stepped out of the living room.

Duncan’s face stayed completely calm the whole time.

After Lucretia left, Taran Ael scratched his head in confusion and looked around at the others in the room: “When she goes out alone, doesn’t she usually just use spells to travel straight there?

“Why did she suddenly agree to walk today…”

Duncan crossed his arms and said, as if it had nothing to do with him: “How would I know.”

…

Sara Mell looked in mild surprise at the “Sea Witch” who had walked into his office.

He was not surprised that she came on time.

He was surprised that this Witch had come in through the front door of City Hall like a normal person, had ridden the elevator up like a normal person, and had walked along the corridor to his door and pushed it open like a normal person.

“I have already opened the window for you,” said the elderly Elven Governor, lifting a hand to point at the open window beside them. “I thought you would fly in as usual.”

“Glass cannot block phantoms. I could come in even without a window,” Lucretia said, giving him a stern look. Her tone sounded a little unnatural. “But today… I just felt like walking a bit.”

“Oh, yes, light exercise is good for the body, especially for a Scholar like you who throws herself into research,” Sara Mell said.

For some reason, he kept feeling that the Witch’s attitude and way of speaking were a little strange today, even the aura she gave off was different from before.

But he soon set that sense of wrongness aside.

“Please sit, and take a look at the letter on the desk.”

Lucretia had noticed that letter from the start.

It was already opened and bore the striking seal of the Church of the Four Gods.

She nodded, sat down opposite Sara Mell, picked up the paper, and let her eyes sweep quickly over the lines.

Soon, the Witch lifted her eyebrows.

The content clearly surprised her—and in that surprise, there was also a hint of subtle “interest”.

She raised the sheet of paper:

“This letter was sent to all the city-states on the Boundless Sea?”

“Yes. The Governors of each city-state should all be receiving it around this time,” Sara Mell nodded.

“I am quite interested in what their reactions will be when they do.

“But before that, I want to hear your view first.

“As Captain Duncan’s Spawn—and as the Spawn who has just reestablished contact with him—what do you think of the Church of the Four Gods’ attitude in this matter?”

Lucretia thought for a moment:

“…The Church. They are more devoted than I expected, and more ‘open-minded’ too.”

“Strictly speaking, it is the four great Pilgrimage Arks whose attitude is open-minded,” Sara Mell said.

“Many people have a set impression of them. They think the popes, and the ‘pilgrim bishop corps’ around them, are the most rigid, rule-bound people in the world.

“But in fact, things are often the other way around.”

“You do not seem to be bound by these ‘common views’,” Lucretia said.

“If you live long enough, you learn more,” Sara Mell shrugged.

“I was surprised for a moment when I first received the letter.

“But after I thought back over what has happened recently, and the Church of the Four Gods’ activities in this period, I was no longer surprised by what it said.”

Lucretia frowned:

“The Church’s recent activities?”

Sara Mell did not answer her directly.

Instead, he suddenly asked another question:

“…When was the last time you ran into a patrol fleet of the Church near the border?”

—

Chapter 549: Witness of the Four Gods

“Ran into a patrol fleet of the Church at the border?”

Lucretia froze for a second when she heard the question.

Then she frowned and began to think.

“It should have been last month.

“I met a Flamebearer’s ship in the border sea…

“After that, I have not seen a Church patrol fleet again.

“But that might just be because I have not gone near the border as often lately.”

“It is not that, Lady Lucretia,” Sara Mell shook his head.

“It is not because you have not gone to the border.

“The Church of the Four Gods truly did pull a large number of people off border patrol to do other things—about half of them.”

“They reduced border patrols?” Lucretia said in surprise. “What are they doing?”

“I do not know. The Pilgrimage Arks have their own secrets, just as all the city-states do,” Sara Mell said.

“They will not report the movements of those ships and crews to me.

“But from the intelligence I have, that withdrawn strength was not moved into the ‘internal routes’.

“They are still staying in certain places on the border.

“You see what I mean?

“They are no longer carrying out patrols. Instead, they have gathered at some special locations near the eternal Veil, as if they are waiting for further orders—or preparing to deal with some much greater trouble.”

The Governor paused, then looked straight into Lucretia’s eyes, his tone especially grave: “This kind of thing has never happened before.”

“…When an Elf says something ‘has never happened before’, that usually means it is very serious,” Lucretia could not help quoting the old saying that was well known among Explorers. “I think I understand what you mean.”

“Yes, my lady. Our world is going wrong,” Sara Mell said softly.

“The Vanished has already sent a warning to the whole world.

“Even someone like me, an ‘ordinary person’, can sense this feeling that a crisis is approaching and things are slowly becoming wrong.

“So the Church of the Four Gods, which has watched and protected this world for thousands of years, cannot possibly have missed it.

“Of course they have already started to act.”

As he spoke, he lifted a hand and pointed at the letter bearing the Church of the Four Gods’ seal.

“This letter links that unusual ‘deployment’ to the warning from the Vanished.

“I think the leaders of the Pilgrimage Arks have already found, or confirmed, the ‘root’ of something your father mentioned in his warning.

“And they have found that this problem is huge—far bigger than anyone imagined.

“In the face of this ‘huge problem’, keeping up their guard against the Vanished is no longer important.

“Even though that ship is still connected to Subspace, and might even fall into Subspace again, they can no longer worry about that—so long as your father now stands on the side of Mortals.”

When he finished, Lucretia stayed silent for a long time.

She lowered her head again and read over the letter, as if still caught in deep thought.

After who knew how long, it was Sara Mell who broke the silence: “May I ask now, Lady Lucretia?

“Your father—the legendary Captain Duncan… what is he doing at this moment?

“And what does he plan to do next?”

He is looking after a child. Next he plans to take those two young ladies into the city to find some food that normal humans can eat…

Those unreliable thoughts flashed through Lucretia’s mind, but she quickly pushed them away.

She let her expression grow serious again.

“He is very interested in the fallen relic I found.

“I do not know why, but he seems to know where the stone sphere at the center of that fallen relic comes from.

“That is mainly what he came for this time.”

“He knows the origin of that ‘stone sphere’?” Sara Mell said, shocked.

“Yes. He called that sphere ‘The Moon’.

“And according to him, in its original—or you could say, ‘normal’—state, its size should be extremely large,” Lucretia nodded.

“He also asked with great interest about the physical properties it shows and the composition of the samples taken from its surface.”

“The Moon…” Sara Mell’s brow furrowed tighter and tighter.

But even after thinking it over for a long time, he still shook his head.

“I have never heard that name before.”

“Nor have I. Father said no one in this world should know that name,” Lucretia said.

“When he said that, his mood… was not very good.”

Sara Mell did not speak for a while.

After some thought, he finally broke the silence:

“The outpost research group has recently taken some more samples from the surface of that ‘stone sphere’. They are doing analysis right now.

“Since your father is so interested in it, I will have them share their findings with you at once.

“And I will warn the heads of the facilities in advance.

“If your father wishes to ‘see some of the research results with his own eyes’, they can be ready.”

Lucretia raised an eyebrow:

“You are not worried about causing panic?”

“You already brought him swaggering into the city,” Sara Mell said helplessly, spreading his hands.

“Do you know how many people in this city recognize his face?”

“But as long as you do not make any public announcement, I expect many people would rather believe he is just a man whose face happens to look very much like his,” Lucretia replied calmly.

“Compared to Subspace Shadows coming into the city for sightseeing, a man who looks exactly like Captain Duncan is easier to accept.”

“Looking exactly like him is frightening enough, my lady,” Sara Mell said with a bitter smile.

“Do you know that ever since your father… since that time, the captains on the Boundless Sea hardly ever grow full beards anymore?”

“That has nothing to do with me,” Lucretia said. “It is not my father shaving them.”

Sara Mell was choked speechless for a moment.

He stared for a while, then finally waved his hand:

“Very well, let us not talk about that.

“My lady, I want to know the truest situation.

“Your father… what state is he in now?”

It was clear that the Governor was trying his best not to sound rude, but he also knew that asking such a question in front of the “Sea Witch” was bound to be a bit offensive no matter what.

He could only grit his teeth and ask.

Thankfully, Lucretia did not seem displeased.

“Just as I learned earlier, he really has lost many memories. Subspace once destroyed his reason and his personality,” the Witch said. Her expression was a little complicated, but she did not hide what she knew.

“The present Duncan Abnomar is, strictly speaking, already a completely ‘reassembled’ person.

“I can still find some shadows of the past in him, and the familiar air and authority I remember.

“And he still has a vague impression of me.

“But that is all.”

She paused, choosing her words with care, then went on:

“If you ask how I feel, I feel that something else is hidden inside him—do not tense up, Sara Mell, I am not talking about Subspace.

“I mean something that is not dangerous, but that I have never seen before.

“It is like another personality, or like many, many personalities and pieces of information layered together…”

“I do not understand what that means,” Sara Mell said, frowning. “Can you put it in plainer words?”

Lucretia thought for a moment, then showed unusual patience as she explained: “This time, when I first saw him, I briefly heard countless noises and saw swelling, writhing light.

“That should count as a mild mental corruption.

“But this corruption faded very fast and did not leave any mark on me.

“And in that corruption, I caught a glimpse of countless points of radiance drifting out behind him.

“It looked… very much like the Starry Sky that floats between the Abyssal Deep Sea, and the Spirit Realm.

“At the very beginning, before I saw that ‘starlight’, my sense of Father was a great ‘nothing’.

“I saw his shell standing there, yet I could not feel that he truly existed.

“Only when those noises and lights appeared did my sense of him become steady, and only then could I talk with him—or, to be strict, talk with that shell—normally.”

Sara Mell’s expression grew even more serious.

“How long did that process last?”

“For an instant,” Lucretia said gravely.

“And it happened on the edge of reason and perception.

“I suspect almost no one else could notice it.

“Those few whose Spirit Sight is high enough to sense it would be completely drawn to that starlight, so they would not even realize that his shell felt ‘empty’ for a moment.”

Sara Mell stayed silent for half a minute, then said thoughtfully: “It sounds as if you noticed that brief ‘process’ only because your attention was fixed on your ‘father’ the whole time…

“Lady Lucretia, what you describe makes me uneasy. To me, it feels as if…”

“I know what you want to say,” Lucretia cut in softly.

“You may think that brief ‘starlight’ is the true Duncan Abnomar now, and that the ‘captain who returned from Subspace’ is only the part it uses to copy a shape—like a sea monster lifting one tentacle above the surface to lure sailors.”

“Is that not the case?” Sara Mell asked, brow deeply furrowed.

Lucretia only shook her head.

“I have my own judgment, Mr. Governor,” she said firmly.

“I know that is him.

“Even though he now shows some unsettling ‘qualities’, even though his way of existing has become hard to understand and beyond words, that starlight is him.

“At least, a part of it is him.”

Sara Mell listened in silence.

After a long time, he finally spoke again, his face very grave: “That sounds like you are being driven by emotion, my lady.

“But I know you are not someone who lets her feelings lead her.

“So I can only hope your judgment is correct—or at least that it comes from your usual, very accurate ‘intuition’, and not from missing him.”

“You can trust my judgment,” Lucretia said solemnly.

Then she pointed at the letter on the desk.

“Or, at the very least, trust the ‘witness of the Four Gods’.”

Chapter 550: Afternoon

Under the weight of the words “witnessed by the Four Gods,” Sara Mell finally and reluctantly accepted Lucretia’s judgment.

No matter what those starlights the sea witch spoke of really were, and no matter what form Duncan Abnomar truly existed in now, at least the leaders of the Pilgrimage Ark, who could speak directly with the Four Gods, had all decided to cooperate with the Vanished. That decision itself was a powerful piece of “evidence.”

Or, to put it in a more extreme way: if even the judgment and orders given by the Four Gods were wrong, then it would not matter whether there was a disaster or not. The very fact that “all Four Gods were wrong” would be the greatest disaster.

“We knew very little about Subspace. All the rules of the Mortal Realm might be overturned in that domain,” Lucretia said. She turned her head and looked out through the floor-to-ceiling windows of the office, as if gazing at the distant sea. Her voice was calm and unhurried as she went on: “When the Vanished ‘returned’ from Subspace to our Mortal Realm, a series of changes had to happen. Remember, back then, just a slight influence was enough to turn the Radiant Star and the Sea Mist into what they are today. So what about the Vanished, after being soaked in Subspace for a century? What about my Father?

“There were many things we should have expected long ago.”

She drew back her gaze from the window and turned her head. She quietly fixed her gaze on Sara Mell's eyes.

"To be honest, I do not even care how much of his 'essence' is still the original Duncan Abnomar," Lucretia said softly. "Even if only a single grain of light in that starlight still belongs to him, I am willing to welcome him back for that one grain. As long as, as a whole, he still stands on the mortal side, that is enough."

Listening to the witch's calm words, Sara Mell's expression shifted several times, then finally settled into a sigh: "Yes. At least he is a friendly existence. That is much better than a true Subspace ghost."

Lucretia did not speak again. She only nodded lightly.

"How is Scholar Taran's condition?" Sara Mell asked after a brief silence. "I heard he fell into a 'dream crisis,' and that you and your Father solved it together?"

"Yes. That was what I was about to tell you," Lucretia said, straightening her expression at once. She spoke very seriously: "The so-called 'dream' that Master Taran Ael fell into may be more complicated than you think. My Father confirmed some information. It is connected to those heretic cultists…"

Over the next ten minutes or so, she told the governor everything she knew, including the goals of the Annihilators and what she had seen of the Sunspawn inside the dream.

After that, she also mentioned the information sent from the city-state of Pland—about the Ender, the Fourth Long Night he had spoken of, and those strange, rambling "sermons."

Sara Mell listened with a serious face from start to finish, not interrupting even once.

Only after Lucretia finished did the office fall quiet for more than ten seconds. Then this governor, who had lived a long and rich life, slowly nodded.

“Nameless One’s Dream…” Sara Mell said thoughtfully. “There is no such term in the elves’ cultural system, but it really does make one think of the demon god Saslokar’s Dream of Creation. However, if such a vast ‘dream’ truly exists, why has no one discovered it for thousands of years? Those heretic cultists say the elves are the ‘passage’ to this dream, but as far as I know, nothing like what happened to Taran Ael ever happened before.”

“We have discussed this too. The most likely explanation is this: the appearance of Nameless One’s Dream is itself one of the signs and proofs that the Fourth Long Night is approaching.”

Sara Mell reacted at once: “You mean…”

“Nameless One’s Dream may have only appeared, or ‘shown itself,’ recently,” Lucretia said gravely. “It might have always been in a dormant state, or in a ‘suppressed’ state, so no one noticed its existence. But as the Fourth Long Night draws near, it is slowly becoming active…”

Sara Mell did not answer. She furrowed her brows, then slowly lifted her head and looked out the window at the bright sunlight. Under the lock of the double rune rings, the Sun was crossing its highest point in the sky. It would soon be afternoon.

She did not know how long she stared before she finally broke the silence in a low voice, almost like she was repeating the Ender’s sermon to herself:

“…dusk is drawing near. The Sun is starting to become ‘gentle,’ and so those who were once banished and erased are beginning to return to this world again…”

…

At the main door, Nina checked her clothes and the things she needed to bring one last time.

The temperature in this southern city-state was much higher than in Pland. Even though it was the cooler end of autumn, she still had to wear light clothes to go out. She put on her favorite dress and matched it with her new light sandals. Her mood became bright at once.

She put the key, some small change, and a map into her little bag. Following Lady Lucretia's advice, she also packed incense strips and medicine to drive away mosquitoes. It all seemed ready.

Last of all, there was the friend she was taking out with her.

Nina turned her head and looked toward Shirley.

Shirley was still wearing her favorite dress. She was squatting down, fastening the straps on her sandals. When she felt Nina's gaze, she looked up at once and asked: "What is it, Nina?"

Nina smiled and asked: "Have you decided where to go?"

Earlier, when they tried the "local specialty food," the shock had been so great that the two girls almost ran back to the ship on the spot. For a moment, they had even felt a real urge to give up and go home.

But in the end, Nina and Shirley did not act on that impulse.

This rare stop at port during a long sea voyage could not be wasted.

"I do not know where to go either," Shirley said as she stood up and patted the dust from her skirt. "That elf uncle said there is a market two blocks away. Let us just go there. Anyway, I really do not want to go to any so-called 'food street' again."

Nina nodded, then glanced at the small pouch at Shirley's waist: "Did you bring the mosquito repellent? This city has many more mosquitoes than

Pland.”

“Yeah.” Shirley patted the pouch at her waist. “Dog reminded me.”

Nina broke into a bright smile: “Good. Then let’s go~”

The two girls walked down the steps in front of the door. Just then, the lock behind them clicked and the door hinges turned.

Shirley jolted and turned around at once. She saw a tall, imposing figure in the doorway and went tense on the spot.

“We… we just want to walk around…” Shirley blurted out before Duncan could speak. She was flustered and rushed: “We already told Mr. Morris…”

“We will not go far,” Nina said with a bright smile. “Just to the nearby market.”

“I know.” Duncan only gave a light nod. Then he walked up to the two young ladies and let his gaze fall on Shirley.

Shirley shrank her neck almost by reflex. She held it in for several seconds before she spoke in a small, careful voice: “Maybe… I should not go…”

“Here,” Duncan said, cutting her off. He held out a few banknotes.

Shirley stared blankly at the money in front of her, unable to react for a moment.

“You are going to the market, right?” Duncan’s voice snapped her out of it. “This is your pocket money for today. Do not spend it all at once. I already gave Nina hers.”

Shirley still seemed dazed. Only when Dog’s reminder sounded in her head did she suddenly come back to herself. She hesitated, then took the notes, which were actually not of very large value, and turned her face away. To

cover her embarrassment, she muttered: “I thought you were going to drag me back to do homework…”

Duncan paid no mind to her reaction. He looked at the two young ladies in front of him and reminded them casually: “Do not come back too late. Try not to go to other districts. If you get lost, call me. I will send AI to pick you up…”

“Yeah, yeah, we know,” Nina said, waving her hand again and again. Her tone sounded impatient, but the smile on her face was as bright as always. Then she grabbed Shirley’s arm and tugged her toward the end of the street. “We are heading out then! We will be back before evening!”

Shirley let herself be pulled along, still a bit muddled. She looked back halfway, her lips moving as if she wanted to say something. In the end, she did not say anything. She only smiled suddenly and, in the brief gap while Nina was dragging her forward, she waved back at Duncan.

Duncan watched the two girls disappear around the corner. A moment later, he withdrew his gaze and looked at the empty space not far away: “Back from City Hall?”

As his voice fell, Lucretia appeared on the empty ground as if out of nowhere. Like a mirage turning solid, she stepped out of the fading illusion, a hint of surprise on her face: “So you already noticed me?”

Duncan nodded: “I saw you from the start.”

Lucretia turned her head and looked toward the direction where Nina and Shirley had gone.

For a moment, the expression on her face shifted in a subtle and complicated way. Many thoughts seemed to rise and fall in the depths of her eyes. There might have been old memories mixed in, and some faint, nameless feelings. But in the end, she gathered up every trace of change in

her gaze. When she turned back to Duncan, there was only a light smile on her face.

For some reason, Duncan suddenly felt that this witch's mood had become very good—very, very good.

"Has Taran Ael already left?" Lucretia asked suddenly.

"He left half an hour ago. He said he was worried about his laboratory," Duncan replied with a nod, then asked: "What did you talk about with the governor at City Hall?"

"The Church has sent a notice to every city-state. The warning you sent to this world is starting to take effect…"

Chapter 551: Twin Realms

(The whole world seemed to be covered by a thick Veil, and its own senses felt as if they had been shattered and rebuilt a thousand times by an invisible force. The mind could not understand those wild, chaotic signals. The buzzing noise and dim, terrifying lights seemed to carve themselves straight into its nerves, stirring its awareness and stabbing at its thoughts.

It tried to take a step forward. It tried to tell what was around it. It tried to remember itself. It tried to understand its situation now.

Countless hazy shapes crowded around it. Those things had shifting outlines. Hollow spaces with strange, dreamy colors floated on their upright shells. Weird currents flowed in those hollows, making nameless howls and hissing sounds that filled everything with fear.

Then, a warm light appeared in its sense of the world. Following that warmth, the being that had woken from darkness and forgotten itself began to walk forward, slowly….)

Nina suddenly put down the cheap trinket she had been picking up and frowned in confusion. She turned and glanced behind her.

Shirley noticed at once and turned too, puzzled: “Huh? Nina, what is wrong?”

“I do not know…” Nina still looked confused. She frowned and swept her gaze over the crowd behind them. “I suddenly felt something move back there, like someone was staring at us. But it feels like… just a mistake?”

“It is probably your imagination…” Shirley also frowned a little after hearing Nina’s words and looked around the market without thinking. “There are people everywhere here. Maybe someone just happened to look this way?”

Even as she spoke, she carefully checked with Dog in her mind.

“Nothing there,” Dog’s reply sounded quickly in her head. “Just a lot of people.”

“Dog says there is nothing,” Shirley said quietly to Nina. “Its senses will not be wrong.”

Nina blinked, glanced back again, then shook her head: “…I guess it was just my imagination.”

The market was crowded. The stream of people made this originally wide place feel a bit cramped. She saw not only locals all around, but also many tourists in foreign clothes wandering through the stalls. Shouts from the vendors rose and fell in the crowd. It sounded noisy, yet full of life.

In a place with so many people, feeling one or two stray gazes on you was not strange at all.

“Young ladies, are you still buying anything?”

The stall owner’s voice came from across the table, breaking Nina’s train of thought.

“Oh, sorry,” Nina said at once. She gave the owner an apologetic smile, then held up the hair clip and brooch she had just picked out. “These two. Please wrap them up for me. What about you, Shirley? Did you find anything you like?”

“I did not find anything,” Shirley said, shaking her head. “I will look at the next stall.”

The stall owner packed the items, Nina paid, and the two girls went on wandering through the busy market. It was still a long time until sunset. The Sun still hung high above the city-state. They still had plenty of time to play.

(What was skin? What were eyes? What were eardrums? How did it walk? How had it come here?

Starting from the most basic questions, it became confused about everything.

Something annoying kept disturbing its thoughts and memories. It brought it more pain and confusion.

It tried to lift its head and searched for the source of that annoying interference. The thing was hanging high above—a giant… noise.

It felt puzzled, because in its weak and blurry memory, “noise” was supposed to be something invisible. But it felt that what it saw up there really was noise.

A mass of twisted, tangled ripples pulsed and writhed endlessly above. The ripples covered the whole chaotic sky, stirring the dim, drifting lights there. They blended with the countless howls and hisses rising from the ground, making one sick, making one afraid.

It forced itself to take another step, moving in the sea of noise. It carefully avoided those shapeless forms with dreamy hollows on their bodies, the ones that kept hissing and whispering. It moved forward slowly, and kept moving….)

Nina stopped again. This time, she stood in the middle of the road, staring wide-eyed at an empty patch of ground.

In her eyes, a faint golden glimmer quietly rose and floated.

Shirley stopped with her at once and frowned at the empty place too. After several seconds, she finally spoke in a hesitant voice: “I think I felt it too. It was like something was watching us, and it even followed us here…”

“Did Dog feel it?” Nina asked in a low voice, her nerves tensing without her noticing.

“Dog still says it did not feel anything,” Shirley replied in a whisper as she watched the area around them. “But it says that having the same ‘illusion’ several times is worrying by itself. Maybe something that should not be in the Mortal Realm is affecting us…”

Nina nodded lightly and checked the market with the corner of her eye.

Among the people coming and going, she could see the Church Guardians standing by the street.

The “Knowledge Guards” of the Truth Institute were watching over this crowded place. They wore institute-style robes and carried large-caliber revolvers at their waists. Their sharp but calm gazes watched for every small movement in the streets and on the square. The eyes blessed by the God of Wisdom Rahm could sense evil that invaded the Mortal Realm at the first moment.

Yet these Knowledge Guards looked relaxed. They seemed to have noticed nothing wrong in the market.

“That feeling is gone… The Guardians do not seem to notice anything either, but I do not think I was imagining it,” Nina muttered quietly to Shirley.

Shirley answered in the same low voice: “So what do you want to do?”

“…Maybe we should tell those Guardians by the road?” Nina thought for a moment and then said: “Uncle said that if we meet dangerous things like heretic cultists, we should report to the Guardians right away.”

Shirley froze for a second when she heard that. As a violent, rude, uneducated bad child, she really did not have much room in her head for the words “report to the authorities,” and she had not thought in that direction at all.

But when she remembered how Captain Duncan had done “righteous reporting” several times before, a strange feeling rose in her heart again—

As a rough, violent troublemaker, was she really the one whose moral sense was too low, so that her way of thinking did not match this whole family of Eldritch Gods?

After a brief sense of mismatch, she could not help but shake her head: “How would we report it? Are we supposed to go over and say we just keep feeling like someone is following us? The Guardians will think we are just making trouble…”

(It forced itself to think and walked unsteadily forward. It remembered a dark red color, like a thick pile of blood. That dark red glow had floated in the sky in its memory. It had chased it without rest, and chased its… companions.

Companions? What were companions?

New memories suddenly appeared in the depths of its mind. It felt confused, and then finally remembered more.

Ah, it did have companions. It had set out with its companions on a long journey. But what were they going to do?

It seemed… they were going to save the world.

They followed the Prophet’s guidance and headed toward the place where the red light fell, to look for a way to save the world. Many of them had set out together, but the hunter brother and sister fell first. Then that gloomy, quiet mage. After that, several knights….)

Nina still decided they should report to the Guardians first.

Even if it would be hard to explain why they were reporting, professional work should be left to professional people. And just like Uncle Duncan had said—if your attitude was honest, no one would blame you if the report led to nothing. If it worked, you might even earn a reward.

She pulled the unwilling Shirley with her and walked toward the Guardians by the side of the street.

(It stopped trying to think. It moved forward on instinct.

The thick “curtains” of the world drew in around it, as if they were trying to block its path. The buzzing noise gathered in tighter rings. Those strange forms that hissed and whispered paced around with shapeless malice on them, giving off a fear that could not be put into words.

But it only walked faster, moving closer to that light. It was like…

It was leaping toward the only thing in its memory that still felt even a little familiar, the only thing it could still somewhat understand.)

Nina reached the roadside.

A Knowledge Guard in institute robes turned his head, curious about the two girls who looked like they were still in middle school and had suddenly walked up to him.

“Young misses, do you need any help?” the Guardian asked. He smiled and spoke gently.

“We think something is wrong…” Nina began, telling the Guardian the line she had been working out in her head all the way over. “Just now…”

(In that instant, all the Veils and mists became invisible borders. The “real touch” of pushing through the border was the first sharp pain felt by the lost and forgotten one in this New World. It leaped forward.)

A scream suddenly rang out from behind them, echoing through the whole market.

Chapter 552

The passersby screamed in panic and scattered. The academy guard in front of them suddenly jerked his head up and, at the same time, drew the revolver at his waist.

Nina had only managed to say half a sentence when this sudden change cut her off. She grabbed Shirley beside her on reflex, then quickly turned her head to look toward the source of the screams.

The roar and the noise suddenly grew to an unbearable level. Sharp pain shook through her senses. Blinding light filled her ears. Her eyes were stabbed by the noise. Her skin felt as if it boiled and steamed in the wind. An indescribable giant sphere hung high in an equally indescribable sky, swelling and writhing madly.

Malicious things began to stir. Those shapes that swelled and shrank rushed about all around, shaking the whole world with their awful howls.

But… where was their weapon? Where was their armor? Where were their companions? Where… were they?

A horrible, pitch-black “mass” of indescribable shape burst out of the air and slammed to the ground.

The mass looked like some kind of flesh, yet it kept reflecting a cold, metallic shine. Its ever-reshaping surface sometimes threw off colorful phantom light, and in that light something seemed to roar and twitch.

This terrifying thing threw the crowd into panic. Everyone scattered and ran.

Only the two “knowledge guards” on the scene did not hesitate. They drew their pistols and took out their spellcasting tools, then rushed toward that horrifying Mortal Realm Intruder.

Their shouts reached Nina and Shirley’s ears: “Child, run!”

The Guardian’s shout snapped Nina awake. In the chaos that had suddenly erupted, Nina stared wide-eyed at the center of the disturbance.

She did not know if she was just seeing things.

Because in that brief instant, in those first one or two seconds, maybe even less, she felt she had seen something far more unbelievable than that terrifying mass. Yes, in that very first second, that thing had looked… like a person.

She wondered if she had seen wrong, because the moment was far too short. And judging from how everyone around her reacted… no one else seemed to have noticed that scene.

The guards had already rushed forward. Because they still could not tell what strange traits this suddenly appearing Intruder had, they did not fire rashly. Instead, they first smashed several test tubes on the ground nearby. The volatile reagents inside quickly spread into the air, forming a thin mist that gathered into a “wall of air” that did not disperse. sunlight shone on it and refracted into a dizzying glow.

It was as if some rainbow-like crystal barrier had formed in the surrounding cloud of gas.

The two Guardians stepped into the “wall of air” first. One aimed his gun at the swelling, writhing thing rolling on the ground. The other quickly scattered potions and powders over the ground nearby, lit a portable

candlestick, then used crystals and metal blocks to build a temporary protective barrier, suppressing the thing's movements.

A sharp whistle then sounded from the other end of the street. The Guardians patrolling other parts of the market hurried over to help. As they drove off the remaining pedestrians on the road, they stepped into the "wall of air" and skillfully began a series of sealing, suppression, and purification procedures.

Nina and Shirley stood not far away, watching all this in a daze. They did not feel nervous. They just thought it was very new and strange.

Because even though they had already run into quite a few supernatural incidents by now, they had hardly ever seen how professional Guardians "handled an incident by the book."

Trained ordinary persons followed strict operating rules and worked together smoothly to control the Intruders that suddenly appeared in the Mortal Realm. This scene was very different from how Uncle Duncan (the captain) usually solved problems.

Right then, the "mass" in the center of the "wall of air," which shone with a metallic luster like some kind of living steel, suddenly thrashed violently. The temporary seal that the Guardians had hastily built with a ritual was hit at once. The transparent shell that covered the Intruder's surface cracked inch by inch, giving off a harsh, shrill tearing sound. The two knowledge guards who were maintaining the ritual's suppression staggered back a few steps, and the crystal prism in one man's hand shattered in an instant.

But that seemed to be the Intruder's last struggle.

The Guardians recovered from their panic and were already ready to reinforce the seal again, but then they saw that the "living steel" in the center of the site was quickly slowing its writhing, as if its life was draining

away. The strange hissing and scraping sounds coming from inside it grew lower and lower. Its heaving surface also seemed to freeze, as if it were solidifying. A dull gray color spread across its metallic “skin,” like stone weathering at high speed.

In the end, the whole thing almost stopped moving. Only a few faint twitches, like the muscle spasms of a dead animal, still ran across its surface from time to time.

“Target activity has dropped. It has stopped reacting to Catalyst No. 17.”

One Guardian, holding a revolver in one hand and several test tubes in the other, spoke quickly.

Another Guardian held a very thick book with both hands. While he stared hard at the “living steel” in the center of the site, he sensed something. A moment later he said: “The target has no mental activity.”

“There are still signs of movement in the central area, but they are fading… No tendency to communicate outward has been detected.”

“Insensitive to the Class III catalyst group. It does not belong to any known type of Intruder… When will the team from the academy get here?”

“The message has been sent. The fastest is fifteen minutes.”

“Got it. Everyone stay alert. Watch your own mental state. Do not leave the barrier zone. Report at once if you see or hear anything unusual.”

The Guardians handled the emergency here professionally and quickly. Even though the thing that had entered the Mortal Realm this time was a completely new entity not found in any records, they still did not look at a loss—until a sudden voice came from the side.

“Um… mister Guardian, what is this thing?”

Nina pulled Shirley over to the “living steel” mass that had almost stopped moving. The two unusually bold young ladies carefully examined the “substance” on the ground, which was nearly two meters across. Nina could not help asking curiously.

The knowledge guard closest to them almost jumped on the spot.

This middle-aged man in a robe, whose air made him look more like a middle school teacher than a warrior, turned his head in horror. He saw that the ones standing behind him were the same two young ladies who had first walked toward him, as if they had wanted to report something. He had thought these two young ladies would be evacuated at once. How were they still here?!

And in the next second, this Guardian realized an even more unbelievable fact.

“How did you get in?!”

He stared, dumbfounded, at Nina and Shirley. From the corner of his eye he quickly glanced behind them. The “wall of air” that blocked off the scene still floated a few meters away, perfectly intact. The barrier with its rainbow, crystal-like mist showed no sign of being broken by anyone, and he himself had not sensed any physical body touch that barrier at all…

So how had these two girls, who looked like middle-school students, just strolled right in?!

“I just walked in,” Nina said. When Nina saw the mister Guardian’s stunned reaction and saw the other Guardians around them instantly go on high alert, she finally felt a bit nervous. “I just… walked in, like that.”

Shirley hurriedly nodded. She tried her best to use the acting skills she had practiced since she was little, skills she had not used much lately, and put

on a meek, innocent look: “We were just curious, so we came over to take a look, mister…”

“Walked in?!” The Guardian stared, and his years of training made him silently recite a prayer to Rahm at once. One hand pressed on the grip of his gun, and his eyes locked on the two young ladies in front of him.

A faint layer of silver light appeared in his eyes.

However, Nina and Shirley just stood there, harmless, like two completely ordinary children out shopping.

And Nina really did not know what was going on.

She had seen the ring of mist, but she had only thought of it as some symbolic “boundary,” like a frame drawn on the ground with white paint. She naturally walked in and did not feel any resistance at all—just like how sunlight could naturally pass through glass.

As for Shirley… Shirley also did not feel that barrier.

Because Shirley walked together with sunlight.

The tense and strange standoff lasted for several seconds. The Guardians on the scene were all on edge. A faint silvery glow rose in the eyes of half of them. Rahm’s divine blessing temporarily strengthened their ability to see the truth, so they could observe these two girls who looked ordinary but whose words and actions faintly felt suspicious.

However, they did not find any anomaly.

Only the older middle-aged knowledge guard still felt a faint sense of wrongness in his heart. He kept feeling that something was hidden right before his eyes, hidden deep in the smile of one of the girls. So he could not help looking at Nina a few more times, the light in his eyes flickering.

But all of a sudden, he felt it was not necessary to keep looking. This baseless thought made him unconsciously withdraw the light from his eyes.

The Guardian rubbed his eyes and, in a daze, forgot the feeling of wrongness that had just risen in his heart.

“We’re not disturbing your work, are we?” Nina asked with a hint of apology.

The Guardians looked at one another. Several of them quickly exchanged glances and spoke in low voices for a moment.

The middle-aged Guardian who looked the most senior took a step forward. His expression was serious, and he still kept a slight wariness.

“Sorry, ladies, but could you… come with us for a bit?”

Chapter 553

Go with them?

Nina froze for a moment, then understood what was going on.

Thinking back over the whole event, thinking about what she and Shirley had done before and after that strange thing like “living steel” appeared, she felt it was normal for these knowledge guards to be on their guard. Any incident involving an supernatural intrusion had to bring every person and object that might have suffered corruption into the inspection range as much as possible. This was an iron rule for the Guardians.

Back on the ship, Vanna often talked about her daily work as an Inquisitor, which also included many of the Guardians’ rules. And as Uncle Duncan often said, it was exactly these rules, strict to the point of being harsh, that ensured the city-states could survive in this era of the Deep Sea and let most ordinary persons still live relatively stable lives in this dangerous world.

So she nodded and quietly tugged on Shirley’s arm, to keep Shirley from suddenly blurting out some crude words. Then she looked at the knowledge guard in front of her and said: “All right… but if we don’t go back for a long time, our families will worry.”

“We just need to confirm whether you have suffered mental corruption or subconscious suggestion,” that knowledge guard seemed to relax and patiently explained. “This is a necessary procedure for screening and protection. If there is no corruption, you will be allowed to leave very soon.”

He paused, then added: “After you come to the academy with us, we will first register your basic information. There will be someone specially assigned to contact your family, so you do not need to worry about that.”

“Oh, then let’s go,” Nina said with a smile, then turned to look at Shirley. “No problem, right?”

“What problem could there be?” Shirley muttered. “I’m even a little looking forward to it…”

From Shirley’s tone, Nina heard a kind of waiting-for-a-show mood, even a bit of gloating. Nina knew what this fellow was looking forward to, but she did not say anything more. Instead, she looked again at the “mass” that had almost stopped moving and could not help asking: “Do you know what this thing is?”

“A kind of anomalous entity that has invaded the Mortal Realm, but we cannot tell you the details,” the knowledge guard said in an official tone. “If, after evaluation, it is confirmed as an incident that can be made public, the academy will release the information.”

“Oh…” Nina drew out the sound, then turned to leave with the Guardians. But before going, she still could not help stopping and looking back at the strangely shaped “mass” once more.

It had already grown still. Even the final spasms and tremors had stopped. On its completely solidified, iron-gray outer shell, a rock-like texture was slowly spreading.

…

Inside the “mysterious mansion” at No. 99 Crown Street, with its tall spires and lush gardens, Duncan and Lucretia were chatting about many of the things that had happened in Frostholm some time ago. Not far away, Morris was curiously talking with the clockwork doll Lunie, seemingly interested

in how Lunie was driven. Vanna was not in the sitting room. It was time for her daytime prayer, and Lucretia had set aside a special “prayer room” for this devout Saint of the Storm.

“…When I left, order in Frostholm had already been restored, but it will still take a lot of work to clean away all the corruption left by those ‘elementses’,” Duncan said to Lucretia as he talked about the situation in the north. “I heard Tyrian’s overtime schedule has been lined up all the way into next quarter…”

“He spent half a century living free as a pirate in the Frost Sea. Now he finally has to pay back the debts he owes from that lazy time,” Lucretia said with feeling. “By the way, have you ever gone to the frozen seas even farther north of Frostholm?”

“No, I have not,” Duncan shook his head. “I only heard that there are endless ice fields there, and the solid ice stretches all the way into the deep part of the fog at the border. I am indeed a bit curious about that place, but what happened in Lightwind Harbor concerns me more.”

“It is said that in the frozen seas north of Frostholm, some ice layers even hold relics left by explorers from the Dark Age and the old Age of City-States. Some people once tried to walk across those ice layers to explore the fog, but in the end they were swallowed up by sudden extreme cold… Compared to that, I think the warmer southern seas are more suitable as a breakthrough point to challenge the ‘border’…”

“If I have the chance, I really do want to see that border… Don’t worry, I know how dangerous that fog is. I’m just very curious…”

“As long as you do not rush into that fog again, it’s fine.”

The two “father and daughter,” reunited after a long time, chatted on and off. They talked about the things that had happened lately, the many

incredible phenomena on the Boundless Sea, the fog at the border, and those dangerous regions far from the civilized world.

Their topics did not always flow smoothly, and Lucretia was not someone good at chatting, but somehow they had still talked like this for a long time.

But suddenly, Duncan stopped.

He seemed to “hear” something. His brows furrowed slightly. After a brief moment of focused sensing, he turned his gaze to a certain direction outside the window.

Lucretia noticed her father’s change at once: “What happened?”

“Nina is calling me,” Duncan turned his head with a strange look on his face and glanced at Lucretia. “…How do you get to the district academy?”

“The district academy?” Lucretia froze for a moment. “What are you going to the district academy for?”

“To fish someone out.”

Lucretia: “…?”

…

“Name?”

“Nina.” Nina hesitated for a moment and did not say the “surname” she used now.

The registrar across the table did not think much of it, and simply kept taking down notes as a routine: “Age?”

“Seventeen.”

“Occupation?”

“I’m still in high school…”

“Are you a local of Lightwind Harbor?”

“I’m from Pland. I came to Lightwind Harbor to travel and I’m staying for now at… a relative’s house.”

The registrar recorded each piece of basic information. Hearing the girl’s honest answers, he looked up with a smile and spoke in a gentle, soothing tone: “Don’t be nervous, young lady. These are just routine forms. You didn’t do anything wrong, you were only accidentally caught up in an supernatural incident. These records are for your protection—don’t be afraid.”

“I’m not afraid,” Nina said very obediently. Then she glanced at the registrar mister with a bit of embarrassment. “Just try not to be scared later.”

“Me? Why would I be afraid?” The registrar was startled for a moment, then waved his hand with a helpless smile. He just thought this was a young lady with little experience of the world talking nonsense because she was nervous, and did not take it to heart. “Ah, if only your companion were as well-mannered as you.”

Nina froze for a second and pricked up her ears to listen to the sounds from the next room. As expected, she heard some very Shirley-style *crude language*.

But it did not sound like she was screaming curses at anyone. It was just some swear words for venting, like when someone talks and casually adds in many phrases with a high “your mom” content. In Shirley’s own words, those were all “intonation particles.”

So Nina relaxed a little and smiled awkwardly: “This is already her being pretty restrained.”

“It’s fine. In our position we have seen all kinds of people, especially people who have come into contact with supernatural powers. Unstable minds, even people who start hitting and smashing things, are normal. We are used to it,” the registrar said casually, waving his hand. “It’s just a little surprising is all. She clearly looks like such a well-behaved young lady…”

Nina thought back to how Shirley behaved in front of Uncle Duncan and secretly thought that, from a certain angle, the registrar’s first impression was not wrong…

After a little while longer, she asked curiously: “When can we go back?”

The registrar, who wore the robe of a cleric from the Truth Academy, turned his head to look at the incense and the quietly burning candle on the table beside him.

“We have to wait until the incense burns out and the candle flame goes out on its own. If none of the catalysts react, then you can leave.”

“Oh,” Nina nodded. After staying quiet for only a few minutes, she asked again: “What about that ‘thing’ that appeared at the market earlier? Has it been caught?”

“Sorry, I can’t say,” the registrar shook his head, then added a reminder. “I suggest you stop paying attention to it and try to avoid recalling it. Some ‘foreign things’ that invade the Mortal Realm can produce a parasitic effect in the minds of witnesses. Although we have not yet found signs that you or your companion have suffered this kind of corruption, frequent recall and too much curiosity could still bring bad effects.”

“Oh.” Nina nodded again, then finally quieted down, as if she were patiently waiting for the incense to burn out and the “inspection” to end.

The young registrar sitting opposite her quietly let out a small breath. As he tidied up the forms he had just filled out and shifted his sitting position, his

hand slid out from a hidden compartment under the table.

A small device shaped like a pocket watch had appeared in his hand.

Hidden by the tabletop, he pressed the cover of the device. The “watch cover” opened with a soft sound, but beneath it there was no dial and no hands. Instead there was a surface like mercury. The “mercury” rose and sank slightly, as if it were some kind of living thing.

He carefully tilted the “mercury” toward the girl across the table and closely watched the changes on the silvery surface.

This girl named Nina looked sane, spoke clearly, and was even very well-mannered. But that could not ease the worries of a professional clergy member. Many times, people who had already suffered mental corruption could still keep this kind of “clear mind” for a short time. If they were not checked carefully, corruption could easily slip out unnoticed.

According to the report from the field team, this girl and her companion had taken the initiative to approach the patrolling knowledge guards in the few seconds before the “invading thing” appeared. During the incident they had also shown many actions that did not follow common sense. These abnormal points all clearly needed to be checked with care.

Yet the surface of the mercury did not show even a trace of an anomaly.

The “registrar” frowned and brought the device closer to his eyes, carefully examining the slight changes as the surface rose and fell.

Suddenly, he seemed to truly see something in the faintly rippling mercury surface—

It was strands of golden light.

It was fire gathering together.

It was some mysterious, vast power, ancient lost knowledge, the mighty light and heat that had existed since the beginning of time, the source of all things in the world…

A roaring sound echoed in his mind. Knowledge like a storm crashed against the edge of his reason. A thirst for Truth seemed to grip his thoughts. The Mortal soul longed for the pull of the Sun. He suddenly opened his eyes wide, fixing a divine gaze on what was about to surge toward him—

A hand suddenly reached in from the side and blocked his view.

“Don’t stare at things for no reason,” a deep, commanding voice sounded in his ear. “You already felt something was wrong and still kept looking. Why do you people from the Truth Academy all have this problem?”

Chapter 554: Truth Keeper

A roar that could almost tear his soul apart kept echoing in his mind. The chaotic perception of the runaway state churned his reason and then slowly faded with time. After this “storm” had lasted for who knew how long, the registrar suddenly became aware of his own self again.

He heard his own heart pounding wildly. His reason struggled back from the edge of the runaway state to the side of Humans. Only then did he realize what had just happened. He looked up without thinking and turned toward the strange voice.

Duncan stood in front of him, with spirit form flames still floating behind him, not yet fully gone. His tall figure was like a dark cloud falling from the sky, giving off an indescribable pressure.

The registrar thought for a moment and suddenly remembered what the girl named Nina had said to him earlier: “…Just don’t be scared later.”

He now recognized the tall figure before him. For an elf, something that had happened a hundred years ago was not that far in the past.

But before he could cry out, a gentle power suddenly flowed into his mind. At the same time, a familiar voice came from not far away: “I will take over here.”

The registrar turned his head toward the voice.

A middle-aged man walked into the room. He wore a dark blue academy robe. His hair was already touched with gray, and he carried a thick, heavy

book under his arm. He looked this way with calm eyes filled with fatigue.

“Your Excellency, Truth Keeper!” The registrar looked as if he had just been saved. He jumped up from the table and at once moved away from Nina and Duncan.

He opened his mouth, as if to report something, but before he could speak, the middle-aged man called the Truth Keeper raised his hand and stopped him: “I already know what happened here. From now on, the City-State University will take over this matter. Do not ask about anything else. Your work for today is over. After you leave, go straight to the counseling room and have a mental evaluation. Go.”

The registrar left full of guesses and confusion. Duncan’s gaze fell on the middle-aged elf whose face carried that tired look. After studying him for a moment, Duncan asked curiously: “And who are you?”

“You don’t remember me?” The middle-aged elf frowned in confusion, then soon nodded as if he understood. “Oh, right. I heard your memory was affected by Subspace…”

His voice sounded weak, with a deep tiredness in it, so much that even his surprise did not change his tone. At last he sighed, raised his hand, and pointed at himself: “Ted Riel, the Truth Keeperof Lightwind Harbor. I am in charge of this city’s safety in the supernatural field. We met a hundred years ago. Back then, you often bought me drinks, and we discussed many things about the border.”

Ted Riel? Truth Keeper ?

Duncan frowned. He of course had no memory of this name, but meeting an “old acquaintance” like this did not surprise him. Before coming to Lightwind Harbor, he had already known that many people in this city would be able to recognize his face. After all, a hundred years was not a

long time for elves, and back then the Vanished had often stayed at the edge of the civilized world, dealing most with border cities like Lightwind Harbor.

So after a brief thought, he gave the answer he had prepared long ago: “Sorry, I don’t remember. Subspace took away more than half of my memories. Please forgive me.”

Ted Riel waved his hand. “It’s fine. Forgetting is forgetting. ‘Forgetting’ is Rahm’s greatest divine blessing. I am already used to dealing with ‘forgetting’ anyway.”

Used to dealing with “forgetting”?

Duncan paused for a second when he heard this. He felt there was a faint grudge and hidden meaning in the man’s words, though it did not seem aimed at him. But before he could ask, the Truth Keeperon the other side went on: “I heard Lady Lucretia and the head of the field team give a rough account of what happened. The young lady behind you must be Miss Nina?”

By now Nina had stood up from her chair. She hid behind Duncan and curiously studied the stranger on the other side. When she heard him call her name, she stepped out boldly and greeted him politely: “Hello, I’m Nina.”

Then she lifted her face and looked at Duncan with some guilt: “I’m sorry, Uncle Duncan… Did I cause trouble for you?”

Duncan laughed and reached out to ruffle Nina’s hair: “It’s nothing. Don’t worry about it.”

As he spoke, he was thinking about something else. Getting pulled into an supernatural incident by accident while trying to report an Anomaly to the

Guardians was still better than rushing through the city center with a bunch of ghost sailors and getting thrown into the station by the constables…

Compared to the commotion Lawrence had caused back then, the trouble Shirley and Nina stirred up was already very harmless.

Thinking this, he could not help asking: “Where is Shirley?”

As soon as he finished speaking, he heard footsteps at the door. Lucretia came in with Shirley and said: “Dad, Shirley is here.”

Shirley looked tense and uneasy. After she entered the room, she carefully checked Duncan’s expression. Then she hurried over in small guilty steps while speaking fast: “I didn’t do anything bad! Nina and I were going to report the situation to the Guardians, but then some weird thing suddenly showed up out of nowhere, and those Guardians got all jumpy and had to drag us off…”

“Oh, I apologize to you both on their behalf,” Ted Riel said as he turned to look at Shirley. “But this is a necessary safety procedure.”

Halfway across the room, Shirley jumped at the unfamiliar voice coming from the side. She turned and glanced at the plain-faced middle-aged man who had felt almost invisible until now: “What, there’s someone else here… Uncle, who are you?”

“He is Ted Riel, the Truth Keeperof Lightwind Harbor,” Lucretia answered from the side. The sea witch nodded to Ted Riel in greeting, then added, “He’s about the same as this city-state’s Gatekeeper or Inquisitor.”

As soon as Shirley heard that, she rushed to Duncan’s side.

Ted Riel stared at her exaggerated reaction, stunned for a moment. Then he turned to Lucretia: “…Am I that scary?”

Lucretia spread her hands: “I guess it has nothing to do with you.”

Duncan turned to look at Shirley, who had rushed to his side: “I see you getting along just fine with Vanna most of the time. How come you’re scared of Inquisitor types now?”

“How is that the same?” Shirley shrank her neck and peeked at the Truth Keeper , muttering under her breath: “Vanna has already joined the gang. This one isn’t one of us…”

Duncan glared at her at once: “Team. I’ve told you many times, it’s a team!”

“Oh…”

Duncan sighed helplessly and shook his head. Then he looked up at Ted Riel and at Lucretia, who was walking over: “I’ve already heard the general situation from Nina, so let’s skip the explanations and polite talk. I want to see that ‘weird thing’ Shirley mentioned. Is it in this facility?”

“Sample containment room 24, in the underground archive of the central sector,” Ted nodded. “I’ll take you there.”

After he spoke, the tired-looking Truth Keeper took out the thick heavy book from under his arm, casually flipped to a page, and tapped it with his finger.

In the next instant, that page flew out of the book and into the air. Duncan saw a door drawn on it, its surface covered with countless deep and complex symbols. As a series of dazzling changes and reshaping took place, the door drawn on the paper quickly transformed into a phantom doorway hanging in the air.

The half-transparent ghostly door opened. Behind it, a hazy view of a corridor deep under some facility appeared.

Duncan watched this with surprise on his face. His first thought was that it really was worthy of the most educated faction in the world. This Truth

Keeper from the Truth Academy did look a bit more impressive than Vanna’s jumping slash.

His second reaction was curiosity. He wondered what would happen if he grabbed that page out of the air while it was unfolding. This bold idea hovered in his mind for a moment, and in the next second he noticed the subtle look Lucretia was giving him from the side.

“Dad, don’t touch anything.”

The witch silently mouthed the reminder.

Duncan calmly turned his head away and put away his bold idea.

Then, under Ted Riel’s lead, Duncan, Lucretia, and the wide-eyed, curious Shirley and Nina passed through the floating phantom door one by one.

A brief wave of dizziness and disorientation soon ended. When the light and shadow in front of their eyes came together again, they had already arrived in what Ted had called the underground archive of the central sector.

A deep, long corridor appeared in Duncan’s sight. Bright gas lamps lit both sides. Near each patch of light, he saw carved stone slabs set into the walls, marked with the holy symbols, emblems, and verses of the God of Wisdom Rahm. The corridor had a heavy, solemn air. At set intervals there were emergency isolation gates, and between these gates stood small rooms with doors tightly shut.

“This is the containment sector,” Ted Riel said. He glanced at the two young ladies beside him, who both looked very curious, and explained: “Suspicious samples discovered for a short time, Anomaly objects of medium danger or lower, and various items that have suffered corruption and cannot be destroyed quickly will all be locked in these rooms according to their danger level and containment method. Do not walk up to those doors without thinking. The things inside are not very well-behaved.”

As if to prove the Truth Keeper’s warning, faint sounds came from some of the small rooms along the corridor as he spoke. There was the rasp of chains scraping, whispers like someone talking in their sleep, the sickly slosh of thick liquid, and footsteps that kept sounding behind a door as if something might walk out the next second.

Shirley and Nina pulled back their curious gazes at once. Their faces finally showed some serious tension.

Duncan’s eyes swept over the small rooms with their many security measures.

In the next second, the whole corridor fell silent.

“Now they’re behaving.” Duncan nodded in satisfaction.

Chapter 555: It Lives

The corridor in the underground archive became quiet.

This place lay under the highest-level City-State University of Lightwind Harbor. Compared to city-states managed by the Deep Sea or the Church of Death, this place was like the central Cathedral of the whole city. Any sealed object held in a place like this was of course far from ordinary. It had to be at least an Anomaly in the top hundred, like Alice, or a vessel of corruption with a similar level of threat.

Anomalies and corruption vessels of this level shared one trait: the features of a living thing.

They might have incredible thinking abilities. They might have ways to speak with people. They might be able to move and try to escape. No matter how strong or weak these “living traits” were, they at least reached the instinct to seek benefit and avoid harm, just like Alice back then, who had instinctively behaved herself even when she had not known Duncan at all.

In short, they had a bit of a brain. Not much, but they were afraid of dying.

Duncan liked things that had a bit of a brain. They made many things easier.

Lucretia looked over with a touch of awe. Nina and Shirley first widened their eyes in shock, then lifted their chins in pride. Duncan had no idea what they had to be so proud about.

Ted Riel was stunned for a moment. His gaze at Duncan turned complicated. It did not hold the fear of an ordinary person, but it also held

no wariness or hostility. He seemed to be thinking about something. After a few seconds, he suddenly said: “While you’re staying in Lightwind Harbor, you can come walk around here more often.”

“Oh?” Duncan was a bit surprised. “Other city-states, when dealing with me for the first time, have all wished I would stay far away. A place like their central Cathedral would be heavily guarded right away. Why are you inviting me here instead?”

Ted raised his hand and pointed at the now quiet corridor: “If you’re here, I can take a vacation.”

Duncan: “…?”

Yet the Truth Keeperdid not care about anyone’s subtle reaction to his words. He just said it, then walked on toward the deeper part of the corridor.

The others followed. This time Duncan fell back a few steps on purpose and walked beside Lucretia. He lowered his voice and asked: “I don’t remember anything about this Truth Keeper. Has he always been like this? I mean… this feeling like he has worked overtime his whole life.”

Lucretia also lowered her voice: “Lord Ted is in charge of the graduating class right now.”

Duncan froze at once: “…The leader of the Guardians in a city-state has to do that too? I remember Vanna, back when she was an Inquisitor, didn’t have extra work like this.”

“divine gifts are closely tied to the words and actions of believers. Studying and spreading knowledge are part of how Rahm’s believers ‘carry out holy work’. Because of this, the whole priest system of the Truth Academy is built in the form of an academy. High-ranked priests must serve as mentors and teach students. The higher the rank, the heavier and harder the teaching

duties are. So the Truth Keeperhas to take on a graduating class, and it’s the hardest class to handle.”

Duncan: “…”

As he listened to Lucretia talk about this strange new knowledge, Duncan felt something odd rise in his heart. He could not help lifting his head to look at the Truth Keeper walking ahead.

Ted Riel, walking in front, sensed the gaze at once. He turned and glanced back, a hint of doubt rising in the Truth Keeper’s mind.

This Captain Duncan, whose memories had been damaged by Subspace and who had acted like a stranger to him just now, was suddenly looking this way with a gaze full of inexplicable understanding, nostalgia, and sympathy. Why?

After a brief moment of doubt, Ted Riel shook his head and stopped in front of a door near the end of the corridor.

“Here we are. containment room 24.” He raised his hand and pointed at the door in front of them.

Many Sacred Sigils were drawn on this door. It seemed to be made of black steel, with tiny silver-white metal grains inlaid in its surface. Shirley looked at the door a few times in curiosity, then felt as if her gaze was being pulled into that deep black and those silver specks. A feeling like her senses were drifting out of her body rose in her. She got scared and quickly pulled her eyes away.

Nina raised her head and looked back at the corridor they had come from, then looked around containment room 24. She frowned in curiosity: “There isn’t even one guard here? In a place this important and dangerous, don’t you assign anyone to stand watch?”

“There are wardens at the necessary Nodes, but near the containment rooms themselves, the fewer people the better,” Ted Riel said. He gave the curious girl a glance as he explained: “Some Anomalies have the ability to parasitize minds and jump between them. If there are too many wardens near a containment room, it actually gives those things a chance to break out.”

“For most Anomalies and corruption-tainted items, the right sealing method is far more important than the number of guards,” Lucretia added from the side. “A stone placed in the right spot or some metal powder scattered on the ground can keep some Anomalies quiet for years. But one extra person might let a formless power break out of containment. So in many sealing facilities, the core area actually has the fewest people. Most of the sealing measures take effect on their own with no one around.”

“The guards posted outside the core area are there less to deal with the monsters inside and more to deal with intruders from outside, to keep anyone from coming in and breaking the containment conditions,” Ted Riel said with a nod. He put his hand on the door of the sample containment room. With a light click from somewhere, the door opened. “But… this sample we brought in this time is the most unusual one I have ever seen. I’m not even sure if we should keep it in a sample containment room or in some other place.”

The door opened. A bright but not very large room appeared before them. Complex and precise holy symbols were drawn all over the floor and walls. Oil lamps treated with special oils and gas lamps on the walls were so many that it was surprising. Other than that, the room held no extra furnishings or furniture. Only in the center stood a square platform, and on it lay that strange “sample”.

A member of the clergy stood by the platform. He wore an academy robe and a strange black mask on his face. Heavy shackles bound his hands

together. He seemed to be the warden of this containment room. When Ted Riel led the group into the room, this “warden” with the odd shackles on his hands looked up, let his gaze rest on Ted, and gave a small nod.

“Has the sample shown any signs of becoming active?” Ted asked.

The warden silently shook his head.

“Any sign of the shackles opening?” Ted asked again.

The warden lifted his hands to show the shackles on his wrists to the Truth Keeper, then shook his head again.

“Good. Thank you. Go take a rest,” Ted said, looking relieved. He nodded slightly. “I’ll take over here. Remember, you must personally put the ‘shackles’ back on the ‘statue’s’ hands. Do not try to switch places with the statue. Do not respond to its ‘calls for help’ in any way.”

The warden nodded without a word and turned to leave the room.

“Those shackles are part of Anomaly-087, the ‘Statue’,” Ted Riel explained to Duncan and the others after the warden left. “Through a special ‘contract’ ritual, we can borrow the shackles from the Statue for a limited time. Anyone who wears the shackles cannot speak, and while wearing them can bind and restrain one chosen entity in front of them. We usually use it to help control newly discovered dangerous items whose nature is still unclear.”

“For example… an intruder from the mortal realm with a mysterious origin who suddenly appeared in the marketplace.”

Lucretia muttered softly, then looked up at the strange mass on the platform in the center of the room. It seemed quiet and still and had a dull iron-gray metallic sheen.

That thing looked like a lump of steel that had cooled and hardened. Yet the lines and contours on its surface still held a strange feeling of softness and smoothness, as if it had once writhed like some kind of soft-bodied creature and then rapidly solidified into this shape. On its smooth “skin” there were, here and there, some angular bulges. Those bulges gave the feeling that…

it was as if something inside the mass was trying to break out.

“These bulges appeared after the sample was brought into the containment room,” Ted Riel explained. “In the few minutes after it arrived, it suddenly became very active again, and its surface changed a lot. We thought it might try to break out of the seals here and even considered sending it to a higher-level containment sector. But after those few minutes, its activity dropped sharply again and kept falling to what you see now. It’s almost just a solid piece of metal.”

“Almost?” Duncan caught the key word at once.

“Yes, almost, because it is actually still ‘alive’,” Ted Riel said with a nod. “In the very core of this mass there is always a faint active ‘signal’. Even though the whole thing has solidified like this, that core is still moving. You can even hear it -”

As he spoke, the Truth Keeper opened his strange book again. He turned to a page and tapped it lightly with his finger.

A device like a stethoscope appeared out of thin air in the air above the page.

Ted Riel tucked the book back under his arm, picked up the “stethoscope”, and hung it around his neck. Then he carefully pressed the other end to the surface of the “solid metal” mass.

In the next second, a rhythmic sound echoed through the whole room –

Thump, thump, thump…

“It has a heartbeat,” Ted Riel said as he raised his head. “Inside this mass of metal, there is a heart that is still alive.”

Chapter 556: Contact

“Before we know more, we cannot rush into destructive tests on this substance—especially after confirming that there is a living heart inside it.”

Ted Riel spoke as he opened his heavy tome again and slid the “stethoscope” back between its pages. His face always looked tired, but now a trace of a complicated emotion appeared there.

“To be honest, this was the strangest ‘thing’ I had ever seen in my life. I had seen plenty of unspeakable creatures invading the Mortal Realm, but a lump of metal with a heartbeat was not so common—and it was so… quiet.”

“Quiet?” Lucretia frowned without thinking when she heard that.

“Yes. Quiet, almost harmless,” Ted Riel nodded. “As you can see, its ‘shell’ had almost solidified. According to the field team, it was violently active for a short time right after it entered the Mortal Realm, but it soon shifted toward this ‘solidified’ state. It also showed none of the ‘active traits’ we usually see, such as trying to escape containment, corrupting Wardens, or resisting outside probing…”

The Truth Keeper slowly shook his head as he spoke: “Among ‘living anomalies’, this was very unusual. Trying to break out of containment is the most obvious trait of all ‘living anomalies’.”

Lucretia stayed quiet for a moment. Nina, beside her, slowly showed a thoughtful look. No one knew what she was connecting in her mind, when she suddenly said: “It kind of felt like… it had nothing left to live for?”

“That is an interesting… idea, though I do not think this living metal would have such a human reaction,” Ted Riel lifted his eyelids and glanced at Nina, but it was clear he did not really take that wild thought to heart. “I am more inclined to think it simply could not adapt to the environment of our Mortal Realm, but as time passes, it might slowly adapt. When that happens, its activity could rise again.”

“Tell me what happened at the market,” Duncan suddenly broke the silence. His gaze fell on Nina and Shirley. “Nina, when you contacted me, you said that you and Shirley had felt strange watching eyes on you and were about to report it to a Guardian by the road, and then this ‘thing’ suddenly appeared?”

“Mm-hmm.” Nina nodded at once. As she spoke, she tried to recall the scene. “Shirley and I felt it several times. It was like some gaze kept falling on us now and then, and there was also a presence that kept getting closer. I think it must have been this thing. Later, when Shirley and I were about to find someone to report it, it finally could not hold back and jumped out, and then…”

She suddenly stopped there. A very hesitant look crossed her face. She hesitated for several seconds before speaking again, frowning slightly and sounding unsure: “And there was a very wrong detail. I don’t know if I saw it wrong. When this thing first appeared, in the instant I caught it in the corner of my eye, I thought… I thought it was a person.”

Nina’s tone was full of doubt, but what she said made the room fall silent at once. Even Ted Riel, who always looked tired and lazy, suddenly opened his eyes wide. But before he could speak, Shirley, who was closest to Nina, was the first to shout: “Huh? What did you say? You’re telling me this thing looked like a person at the start? And you didn’t tell me?!”

“The field team’s report did not mention this,” Ted Riel said. His expression turned unusually serious. “Miss Nina, are you sure?”

“That’s why I said I don’t know if I saw it wrong,” Nina answered nervously. “The market was in chaos at the time. People were running everywhere. Maybe I got it wrong… or maybe the Guardians on site missed it? It was only the very first instant, after all…”

“Not likely. The Guardians have strict ‘contact record standards’ for first contact. Many anomalies can change themselves very fast or evade cognition, so we require the people handling ‘first contact’ to carefully record the exact ‘start time of contact’ and to state whether their gaze shifted at any point, so we can confirm whether the team had any ‘observation gaps’ when watching the target…”

Ted Riel briefly explained the work rules of the Knowledge Guards, then shook his head: “According to the field team’s report, they made contact the very moment the target entered the Mortal Realm. At least two Guardians were already watching the place where it would appear before it actually showed up. Through the entire process, at least one person was looking right at it. There was no chance for a gap.”

As soon as he finished speaking, Duncan suddenly broke the silence: “But I believe Nina.”

Ted Riel froze for a second, then seemed to realize something: “…You mean?”

“At least from Nina’s point of view, this ‘Intruder’ looked like a person for a moment at the start,” Duncan said calmly. Then he glanced at Shirley. “You were with Nina the whole time. You did not see that, right?”

“No,” Shirley shook her head at once. “I didn’t see it looking like a person.”

“Different observers, different ‘forms’ of the same target?” A strange light flashed in Ted Riel’s eyes. He looked at Nina with surprise and thoughtfulness. “And only Miss Nina saw something different from everyone else… why?”

Curiosity clearly took hold of him. His gaze soon fell back on Duncan: “Does Miss Nina have something special about her?”

The Truth Keeper seemed truly puzzled. He did not know Nina’s background. Without actively using Spirit Sight to examine her, Nina looked, to outsiders, like an ordinary seventeen-year-old young lady—but there was no doubt that this ‘ordinary young lady’ had to be special.

Just the fact that she could stay on Duncan Abnomar’s ship proved that.

“Have you heard of the ‘Black Sun Descent’ in Pland? If you have, you should know that when the Vanished left that city, they took a fragment of the ancient Sun with them,” Duncan said, lifting his hand to point at Nina. “She is that fragment.”

He ignored the wonderful change that flashed across Ted Riel’s face and focused again on Nina: “Do you still remember what that ‘person’ you first saw looked like?”

Nina tried hard to recall. After a while, she finally spoke: “It looked like someone wearing strange ancient armor, the kind you see in history books, all wrapped up like an iron can… oh, and there was a ragged scarf or a short cloak? I only saw it for an instant, so I’m not sure about many details…”

She paused for a moment, then added: “Because of the helmet, and the armor looked so heavy, I couldn’t tell what the person inside looked like. I didn’t even know if it was a man or a woman. But I could feel that the armor was tattered, like it had gone through many battles.”

“A Warrior in ancient armor…” Lucretia muttered. She thought quickly, then asked: “So how did that ‘person’ turn into a lump of living metal? Did you see that process?”

“No.” Nina shook her head. “It changed in an instant. It just became like this, as if there was no gradual change at all… Maybe I blinked? I’m sorry, I really can’t remember clearly…”

“Remembering this much is already very good. You gave us very important information,” Duncan said. He comforted Nina, who seemed a bit down, then turned and walked to the platform where the ‘sample’ was placed.

He stared solemnly at the solidified ‘living metal’, sorting through the information they had so far.

In some first moment, ‘it’ seemed to be a Warrior in heavy ancient armor. The armor was old and worn, scarred by many battles.

Nina had felt gazes fall on her several times and sensed she was being followed. That meant this thing was very likely coming for her—or rather… coming for the ancient Sun.

The market had been crowded, but when Nina first felt the gaze and that tracking presence, no one saw anything strange. That meant ‘it’ either had some ability to disrupt cognition, or it had ‘slipped across’ from a deep layers world like the Spirit Realm into the Mortal Realm…

Duncan slowly reached out and pressed his hand against the surface of the ‘metal’.

Cold, hard sensation spread from his fingertips.

He seemed to feel the heart buried deep inside the metal, to feel its slow beating and the low thud of its pulse.

It was alive, living in a way Humans could not understand.

It seemed to have held some purpose, but then something went wrong at the last step. It had revealed itself from hiding and pounced at Nina and Shirley. It clearly had not meant to end up as this lump of solid metal in its final move.

Ted Riel watched Duncan's action with some tension, then almost without thinking glanced toward the Witch standing nearby.

Lucretia only shook her head, signaling him not to interfere.

Tiny ghostly green sparks appeared at Duncan's fingertips.

He carefully controlled that small flame, making sure it did not ignite this metal that was clearly in the supernatural category. He guided the flame to seep into the metal, feeling its flow of life, its heartbeat, and the thoughts that might exist within it.

Yet what answered him was only a vast emptiness and a hazy, chaotic 'touch'.

There seemed to be no information inside this metal that could be 'read'.

But for some reason, Duncan still felt that something was hidden in that empty, hazy, chaotic touch. It was not that he could not find it. He simply could not 'understand' it yet.

"…Who are you?" he could not help asking softly in his heart. "Where did you come from?"

After an unknown time, that great emptiness was still there. But in the faint feedback from the flame, a tiny ripple suddenly seemed to appear.

Duncan seemed to hear a voice—or rather, an 'idea'—rise in his mind:

"We are marching toward Doomsday."

Chapter 557: Marching Toward Doomsday

The Ranger who had been born in the Evergreen Mountains often said this. Every day, when they made camp before sunset, he would look up at the band of Deep Crimson that crossed the sky and sigh those words. In his own phrasing, it was “a rather romantic way to put it”—the greatest courage and the ultimate romance in the world, when Doomsday was drawing near.

But courage and romance could not stop death’s footsteps. The Ranger fell on the last kilometer before a crossroads, an evil arrow driven straight through his chest. It was the most ironic way for him to die—a master of the bow killed by an arrow.

The Spirit Medium took care of the attackers. They were two already-rotten corpses that had lain in ambush on the road, launching their vile attack when the group drew near. Their Undead nature—no breath, no heartbeat—let them slip past the Ranger’s scouting, and the wind carried away the stench from their bodies. Together, it all created yet another unlucky accident, just like every farewell along this road.

The armored Warrior walked to the edge of the camp and sat down on a dry, dead stump. He lifted his head and quietly gazed toward the dusk.

That unsettling band of Deep Crimson stretched across the sky like a blood cut that would soon tear the world apart, sinking toward where the Sun went down. Inside the Deep Crimson, it was as if blood was flowing. It was

also as if countless phantoms beyond Mortal minds hid and brewed there, casting their cold gaze upon this world that was rushing toward ruin.

Footsteps came from the side. The Spirit Medium sat down on the ground next to him and watched that blood-red scar in the dusk together with the Warrior.

Silence lasted for a while. Then a low voice came from inside the Warrior's helmet: "Those two attackers from earlier today…"

"They were that Hunter brother and sister… the first ones to die," the Spirit Medium answered. His voice came from under his black hood, so gloomy it sounded almost like a dead man talking. "They caught up. The dead don't need to rest, so they are faster than we are."

"We buried them ourselves in the forest outside the kingdom's gate, and you even performed the Requiem ritual. Why would the dead you soothed get back up?"

"Many things have been getting back up along the way," the Spirit Medium said quietly. As always, he showed no emotional ups and downs. His words were only the cold, sorrowful 'statement of facts'. "Do you see that Deep Crimson at the edge of the sky? The direction where the red light first fell… It has already grown to twice the size it was when the Prophet first made his prediction. It is a wound that has cut open our world. The earth under our feet and the sky over our heads are both rotting from that wound—and the rot is getting faster.

"The process of going from life to death is starting to become different from what I once understood."

Not everyone could accept his way of speaking. If the Shield Knight were still here, he would already be lecturing them at length, trying to console and encourage everyone.

But when the Warrior looked back, he saw only the lonely figure of the Templar Knight sitting by the campfire. In the Shadows cast by the flames, the small, thin figure of the Pyromancer was curled up. Aside from them, there was no one else left in the camp. The Shield Knight, who had always argued with the Spirit Medium and loved to lecture his teammates, was gone—he had fallen in the wilderness outside Sandstone Fort, his cause of death still unknown.

“Later on, others may ‘catch up’ too,” the Spirit Medium went on. He seemed unused to the quiet of this moment. After a few seconds of silence, he forced the topic to change. “Most likely people who used to be in our group.”

“Why? Just because the Hunter siblings caught up today?”

“Because they still remember their mission to march toward Doomsday—but no longer remember us,” the Spirit Medium said softly. “Before the influence of that red light grew, we did not handle their bodies properly.”

The Warrior was silent for a moment: “…What counts as proper handling?”

“Burning them. Use Wraithfire to burn them completely. Then smash all the larger bones. If possible, soak the skull in acid and bury it deep.”

“All right. I understand.”

The next day, the Spirit Medium died.

They found him lying at the edge of the camp, his heart stolen by some power in the darkness, a gaping hole left in his chest. Strangely, he had a faint, odd smile on his face in death, as if… he was relieved to have escaped this heavy mission ahead of time.

The Warrior, the Templar Knight, and the Pyromancer held a “funeral” for the Spirit Medium. They used Wraithfire to burn his body to ash, crushed

all the bones they could find, then soaked the fragments of his skull in a clay jar filled with acid and buried it at the campsite.

Now, only three people remained.

As the black smoke of burning bones rose into the sky, the Warrior again gazed into the distance at the Deep Crimson that looked as if it was cutting the entire world apart. The Pyromancer came to stand beside him. After a long silence, this small woman finally asked the question no one had dared to speak.

“Are we still going forward?”

The Warrior turned his head and looked at this red-haired Groska woman.

He still remembered what she had looked like when they first set out. Back then, she had been full of confidence. Her eyes had shone with energy, and her words had been full of pride. Chosen by the kingdom and named by the Prophet as the “chosen of fate”, she had believed in her own power and her destined glory more than anyone.

Yet now, she was the one asking this question.

“Of course we are going forward,” the Warrior said in his muffled voice. His heavy visor hid his face, but his tone stayed firm. “We have to save our kingdom and stop the spreading Doomsday.”

“Marching toward Doomsday—can that really stop Doomsday itself?” The Pyromancer looked at him and asked quietly. “At the end of that Deep Crimson, is there really an enemy waiting for us to defeat it? Will everything really be solved once we defeat it, like the Prophet said?”

“The Prophet has never been wrong,” the Warrior said stubbornly.

After a short stare-down, the Pyromancer nodded: “I understand.”

Three days later, as the group passed through a nameless forest, the Groska woman fell on an open patch of ground by a river.

There was no enemy and no trap. She was burned by her own flames. Magic in a runaway state suddenly surged out of her body, like countless living Evil Spirits tearing her apart and burning her to ash in an instant. Her scream was short. Perhaps her pain only lasted for a heartbeat.

The good news was that the runaway state flames burned very cleanly. There was no need for further handling of her remains. In those ashes, they could not find a single bone fragment larger than a fingernail.

Now, only two people were left in the group.

There was the Templar Knight, even more taciturn than the dead mage had been and growing quieter with every day of the journey, and the Warrior himself, forever wrapped in heavy armor.

After they entered the true wilderness, they still marched in a straight line. They did not need to worry about getting lost. The Deep Crimson of Doomsday always pointed their way.

How long would this march last? Where would it end? What would be waiting there… for those who marched toward Doomsday to face their own fate?

In the eyes of the Warrior who walked on and on, the world under the red light became a little stranger every day.

The time when the Sun rose and set had changed a lot and was shifting further each day. Sunset was no longer in the west, but now lay a clearly visible angle to the north.

The sky was slowly being dyed a strange purple-red. From time to time, eerie lights appeared deep in the clouds. Sometimes, it even seemed as if living shapes moved within those lights.

The distant mountains looked as though they had begun to twist. Cliffs that had once been straight now bent and curled like wet wooden boards. Farther away, the horizon itself seemed to rise, as if the whole land… was undergoing a slight change of shape.

Or perhaps there was something wrong with the eyes of the observer.

And along with these many visible oddities, invisible changes were happening as well.

The Magic in the world was changing in strange ways. Power that had once been hard to sense was now as active as a rushing stream. The mage had once complained that, outside the civilized world, it was hard to gather arcane energy from the air. But now even the morning wind seemed thick with Magic. These energies would build up on the surface of metal armor, causing tiny flashes and sparks, and when enough power gathered, they would release with a sharp little pop.

The Warrior felt that these changes might be a sign that the journey was nearing its end. They were close enough to the place where the red light had fallen. It still looked very far away, but hope… seemed almost in front of them.

Yet at a nameless river, the Templar Knight stopped.

This tall, silent woman took off her helmet and suddenly said: “This is as far as I go.”

The Warrior looked calmly at his last companion: “Why?”

“You aren’t surprised?”

“I only want to know why,” the Warrior said in his usual stubborn tone.

The Templar Knight fell silent for a moment, then took a Cracked Ruby from her tunic and set it on the grass beside her.

“The kingdom is destroyed,” she said. “Fire and lava surged up from the depths of the earth and covered the whole kingdom within one hour. The Prophet’s soul held on until the last moment to witness the final outcome.”

Even as he heard this terrible news, the Warrior still stood quietly where he was, looking straight into the Templar Knight’s eyes.

“This journey has no meaning,” the Templar Knight went on. “From the start, it never had any meaning.”

“The Prophet lied to us,” the Warrior said slowly.

“No. The Prophet lied to the people who stayed in the kingdom,” the Templar Knight said softly. “They needed to believe that the kingdom had sent out its finest to end this catastrophe, just like a hundred years ago when we sealed the Eribus that woke from beneath the ground, and seven hundred years ago when we ended the rule of the Frost giants. The world would be saved by heroes. If one hero was not enough, then you sent an army of heroes.”

“…The Prophet does not make mistakes.”

“Yes,” she said, “just as you said, the Prophet does not make mistakes. So he was the first to know how Doomsday would come.”

The Templar Knight spoke and pointed to the ground beside her.

“Sit. We’ve been walking for a very long time.”

The Warrior did not move.

The Templar Knight did not mind. Her silence along the road finally ended. In this last peaceful dusk, she smiled gently for the first time: “You, and many of us, already understood all of this halfway through the journey.”

“Perhaps only that red-haired Groska woman truly believed in that great destiny—she understood a little only when death finally caught up with

her.”

“It might have been better if she never had,” the Templar Knight said with a light shake of her head. Then she stared, surprised, as the Warrior took another step forward. “Where are you going?”

“I am going to keep walking.”

“Why?”

“Aren’t you curious?” The Warrior looked back at her. “After realizing this expedition is meaningless, why do I still keep going? Don’t you want to know the reason?”

The Templar Knight only watched him in silence.

“I want… at least to understand what that truly is,” the Warrior said, looking toward the Deep Crimson in the dusk. “The kingdom is gone. Maybe the whole civilized world is gone. But I still want to walk on… I want to know what is slowly killing the sky and the earth.”

The Templar Knight quietly watched her last companion. She stayed silent for a long time, then finally let out a long sigh.

“You’ll never reach it.”

The Warrior turned his head: “What?”

“That red light did not fall on the earth.”

Under his visor, surprise finally crossed the Warrior’s face.

“When the Prophet’s soul left the earth, he held on for a full hour. In that hour, he stood in a very high place and saw a wider scene. Our world is a sphere floating in endless void. And that light… is larger than the land beneath our feet and farther away than the distant sky.”

The Templar Knight spoke as she bent down and picked up the Cracked Ruby from the grass.

“In the end, he told me that the star scholars’ theories were correct. The relationship between the stars and the land is just as the scholars described: all are stars floating in a vast space. My friend, the Deep Crimson you want to chase is not splitting the land. It is splitting ‘everything’.

“The only thing he could not explain is why we, standing on the earth, always see that light in the same place in the sky. Even though the land beneath us turns and moves like the other stars, the light seems printed right before our eyes, crossing the sky from east to west. So we always thought it had fallen upon the earth…

“That was the Prophet’s last puzzle. Perhaps it will become the last puzzle left to this world.”

The Warrior’s body went still. For some reason, a nameless dread… slowly spread through him.

And so, a very long time ago, in a very distant place, in the last peaceful dusk, one person finally understood the shape of the world beneath his feet —just in time, before Doomsday.

“Take a rest,” the Templar Knight said softly. Before the ever-spreading Deep Crimson covered the sky, this woman who had always seemed so hard and cold spoke gently to someone for the first time. “It’s all over.”

It was all over.

When everything ended, what should one do?

The Warrior stayed silent for a moment, then wordlessly drew the long sword at his waist.

He had once planned to use this sword to defeat the powerful enemy at the place where the red light fell, like the great heroes of legend.

But now, he knew this sword was far too short. It could never reach the stars, much less reach fate.

He and his civilization had not even had time to prepare for fate. A suddenly snuffed-out lamp never knows where the wind comes from.

He raised the blade high, then used all his strength to hurl it into the sky.

In the last instant before the sword left his hand, he seemed to hear a voice in the wind:

“Who are you? Where did you come from?”

The Warrior did not know where the voice came from, or whether it had ever truly existed. In that brief and eternal moment, what rose in his mind was a sentence one of his companions had often whispered in his ear:

“We are marching toward Doomsday.”

Chapter 558: All That They Left Behind

In that final moment, a sharp, icy gleam appeared deep in the boundless void and chaos. The tide of shattered information surged in like a flood and almost drowned the tiny flame that had seeped into the “sample”.

In his brief daze, Duncan heard Shirley beside him cry out: “Careful!”

His drifting awareness overlapped once more with the Mortal Realm. Duncan instinctively stepped half a pace back. The next second, he saw the tip of a sword, flashing with silver light, appear before his eyes.

The tip stopped only ten centimeters from his nose, and it was still slowly extending forward.

“Hostile action!” Ted Riel, who had been staring fixedly at the containment sample, reacted at once. He gave a low shout and quickly slapped the heavy book in his hands. A hazy radiance spilled out from the pages, spread over the surface of the sample, and in an instant condensed and thickened into layer after layer of barriers.

At the same time, Duncan drew back the flame that had seeped into the sample. His mind cleared quickly, and his gaze returned to the “sample” in front of him.

On the containment platform, the lump of iron-gray metal that had been frozen solid suddenly changed shape. Part of its “shell” bulged up in an instant and condensed into something like a sharp sword.

But that suddenly formed “sword” did not pierce anyone. It had only come out halfway when some immense force seemed to yank it back. Even now it was still stretching outward a little at a time. Rather than say it had “stabbed” out, it looked more as if a sword was being slowly “pushed” out of the sample.

At some point, a small conductor’s baton had appeared in Lucretia’s hand. She strode forward two quick steps. While Ted Riel held the sample in check with divine magic, she tapped the baton against the middle of that “long sword”. But just as she was about to destroy that structure further, Duncan suddenly stopped her: “Wait.”

Lucretia forcibly halted the spell she was about to unleash and turned, puzzled, to look at her Father. Ted Riel, who had been about to take the next step, and Nina, who was already almost igniting, also hurriedly stopped and looked over in confusion.

Duncan waved a hand at them. Then he carefully skirted around the still-slowly extending blade and came to the side of the iron-gray “living metal”. He stared fixedly at its “shell”.

It had not truly “come alive”. Only the portion forming the sword blade was changing and stretching outward. The rest of the sample remained as still and frozen as before.

The chaotic, broken information was still swirling in his mind, as if someone had torn a person’s memories into pieces, mixed them together at random, and then dumped them all in front of him at once. Duncan kept sorting through those shattered memories again and again, trying to reassemble them into useful knowledge.

He saw many things—an ominous Deep Crimson, scars that cut across the sky, warriors setting out, companions falling one by one, a world that slowly twisted and rotted, a journey that had no real meaning, vast

confusion, anger, fear, the death and calm that followed, and the strange, shifting scenes that kept surfacing amid Mental Derangement.

Duncan suspected that if any other ordinary person saw these things—even only a small part of them—they would be completely consumed by the dangerous knowledge hidden in that information and fall into utter corruption.

But to him, that corrupting “knowledge” was only a pile of chaotic fragments. As he sorted and recalled them again and again, he had already begun to piece them into a continuous memory.

Then he raised his head and looked at the long sword that had already extended more than halfway out. After a slight hesitation, he reached out and touched its surface with a fingertip.

The chill, solid feel of metal came through his fingertip.

Duncan slowly closed his eyes. When he touched the sword, he could feel those shattered memories in his mind become a little clearer and more continuous. They were still incomplete, but they were enough for him to understand what had happened.

He opened his eyes and looked at the last fragment left behind by that distant, ancient world, at the final strike that nameless warrior had launched against Doomsday. He pinched the fragment gently between his fingers, feeling the link it passed to him, and slowly drew it out.

The flame had given this long sword, which had never managed to fly into the sky, a touch of extra strength. At last it came free from the living metal completely.

It was finely made, with a long, slender blade. The hilt was wrapped in fine linen, and bright crystals of unknown use and material were set into the

guard. Now, after crossing a span of ages, it had arrived in this Deep Sea era in its original and “correct” form.

Everyone in the room, Ted Riel included, stared wide-eyed at the scene before them. Lucretia finally could not hold back and asked: “Dad, what is this?”

Duncan lowered his head and looked at the Nameless Sword in his hand. After thinking for a long time, he slowly said: “This was a weapon once meant to fight the world’s Doomsday.”

“To fight the world’s Doomsday?” Shirley’s eyes widened at once. “With a sword? Is this one of those artifacts from legends that can split the sea? The kind blessed by the Four Gods?”

Duncan shook his head: “It’s only a sword—the best sword they had. It’s very sharp, but even pushed to its limit, it could only kill larger beasts or armed humans… That was already the best they could do.”

Lucretia and Ted Riel looked at each other, unable to understand. Nina, however, vaguely understood and quickly asked: “What did you see?”

Duncan was still sorting through the messy, broken memories in his mind, but after a brief pause he still broke the silence: “Just some fragments, things that happened a very, very long time ago…”

He described what he had seen, using words as simple as he could.

He did not speak quickly, because there were too many missing pieces and too much information that even he did not fully understand. He had to find a way to fill in the parts that did not connect at all, or to explain concepts that were hard for Nina and the others to grasp.

For the first time, he tried to explain to people of this world what a “planet” was. After his last talk with Alice, he had finally decided to give it a try.

But to explain one strange idea, he needed ten more basic points of knowledge. Every strange point needed even more knowledge to support it. On top of that, there were countless things that were totally against common sense and instinct for people of this world. Even if he explained all of it clearly, no one could truly picture it and piece it together in their mind.

Ted Riel and Lucretia struggled to understand, and the questions they kept throwing out made the explanation take longer and longer. In the end, Duncan realized that if he wanted to explain all the basic concepts clearly, he would need at least half a year of full-time lessons to manage it.

So he could only skim over many things, or use metaphors to patch the gaps in knowledge and ideas for now.

In the end, despite all his effort, Nina and the others clearly could only grasp part of it. But at least this time, they more or less understood what had happened.

Shirley was still lost in the shock of that long “story”. Nina was still thinking about the strange words Duncan had just mentioned. The two scholars present—Lucretia and Ted Riel—had dark, heavy expressions. It was clear they had already thought of many things.

“The world’s Doomsday…” Ted Riel murmured under his breath. “If what you saw really points to a world’s Doomsday, then when did it happen…”

“Before the Great Annihilation,” Duncan confirmed the question the other man had not spoken aloud. Then he raised the sword in his hand. “The black wall that has stood before historians for so long now has a crack in it. This sword… might be the first thing we can confirm that was passed from before the time node of the Great Annihilation into this Deep Sea era.”

“A historic moment… just like that.” Ted Riel let out a long, complicated sigh. Faced with news that could shake the whole academic world, his mind

only felt like chaos. A flood of sudden information was battering at the system of knowledge he had built over many years and even at his understanding of this world. In spite of himself, he called in his heart for Rahm's benediction and laid mental wards and suggestions on himself to keep his reason from being damaged.

After a long, silent period of thought, Lucretia suddenly raised her head and met Duncan's eyes: "You mentioned many strange ideas just now. Are those… the things you said before would be hard to explain to me?"

"They're only a small part. A very, very small part," Duncan said quietly. "I should have told you some of this earlier."

Lucretia only shook her head lightly. She did not complain, and she did not ask why her Father was willing to explain these things now. If Father did this, he must have his reasons. When he was ready to speak, he would speak.

She was only a little curious about how her Father knew such unbelievable things.

Did that knowledge… come from Subspace?

On the other side, after a long stretch of thought, Ted Riel suddenly realized something.

"According to what you 'saw', under the influence of that 'red light', the world was swallowed by lava, the land was torn apart, and everyone died… Then how did the Deep Sea era begin?"

He raised his hand and chopped downward with his palm, as if marking a fault in the ground.

"There's a gap here, Captain Duncan. After that world was destroyed and before the Deep Sea era began, there should have been some process of

change. The world you saw does not match any race, any place, or any legend in the Deep Sea era…”

“Indeed, it doesn’t match,” Duncan said with a light nod. His gaze fell on the “sample” sitting on the platform. After a long silence, he finally spoke out a guess he had held in his heart for a long time. “So… that world did not pass down much, unlike the worlds of humans, elves, and Senkin. What we see before us is already all that remains of that world.”

“‘That world’…” Ted Riel and Lucretia traded a quick look. In that moment, they finally grasped what Duncan meant.

And in Duncan’s mind, the “Moon” of his homeland rose once more before his inner eye.

Along with it came the words Alice had once said to him with a laugh—

“Captain, is this a riddle?”

The expression on Duncan’s face shifted slightly. The muscles at the corner of his mouth trembled a few times, then finally settled into a smile that Nina and Lucretia could not understand.

“Yes, this really is a riddle…”

He spoke softly, in a voice only he could hear.

Chapter 559: The Lost Ones

All along, the scholars of this world had made many guesses about the origin of the current Deep Sea era and the world before the Great Annihilation. They had also tried to explain the broken histories, gaps in relics, and contradictions in lineages among the city-states of the Boundless Sea—just as any people who form a civilization will do when they face their history.

Where there is history, there will be people who study history. Where there are people who study history, there will be people who try to explain its contradictions. There is never a shortage of guesses. Anything an outsider could think of, professional scholars have most likely already considered and may even have built into a complete theoretical model.

In fact, scholars had many different models that could explain how the Deep Sea era came to be—including the one Duncan had just guessed. Every one of them made sense.

The only problem was that none of those models had any solid “evidence” to stand on. The Great Annihilation was like a towering wall blocking off everything before that time node. No information or relics could pass down from before that node.

Now, Duncan believed he had found a key piece of “physical proof” and had extracted from it enough vital information to support one of those guesses:

Fragments left after a distant, unfamiliar world was destroyed—and a “memory” that accurately described the scene of Doomsday.

Of course, in front of a truly rigorous scholar, this lone piece of proof might still not be enough. It might not yet fully and beyond all doubt explain the state of the Deep Sea era.

“World Aggregation Theory…” Ted Riel murmured to himself. “I know. My mentor has always been a supporter of that theory. He believes that the present Deep Sea era was formed by layers and rearrangements of many worlds that were originally separate from one another. What caused that stacking and rearranging might have been a great disaster that fell on several worlds at the same time. In that view, the so-called ‘Great Annihilation’ was not one disaster, but a series of disasters that happened all at once. That is why the records of history kept by the races of the Boundless Sea contradict each other so much, and why some ancient legends are torn apart…

“This theory also explains why we can’t find the ‘original form of the world’ from before the Great Annihilation, and can’t find ancient relics that clearly support any single record of history—because those original forms have already been reshaped. From the point of view of the timeline, the ‘world’ we live in now simply did not exist before the Great Annihilation.”

He stopped and let out a slow breath, then went on talking.

“The entire Boundless Sea was born in the moment of the Great Annihilation. Before that moment, there was no ‘Old World’ that could be fully and accurately described and understood. There were only countless fragments of old worlds piled up at the time node of the Great Annihilation as raw material. World Aggregation Theory, among all the origin theories, has the strongest power to explain what we face. It almost explains every problem.

“But at the same time, it is seen as the most fanciful and hardest to prove, because it basically denies that ‘history can be traced back’ at all and throws everything into the box of ‘it has already vanished anyway’. So even though the theory is good, it has very few supporters. My mentor… is one of the few.”

After Ted Riel finished, speaking with a sigh, Duncan finally broke the silence: “Now, we have evidence.”

Ted Riel’s gaze fell on the long sword. After thinking it over with a grave expression for a long time, he still shook his head: “One piece of proof alone is not enough. This evidence does seem very likely to support World Aggregation Theory, but a single piece of proof always has flaws. Unless we can find a second clear ‘world fragment’, and one that comes from a different world than the one your ‘physical proof’ belongs to…”

As he spoke, the Truth Keeper’s tone grew tangled and strained. From an emotional point of view, he wanted more than anyone for a long-standing guess to be confirmed and for them to finally find that “answer”. But as a scholar, he had to be strict. Even when he saw the first “evidence”, he had to act with seemingly cold “harshness”.

When he finished speaking, Duncan only gave a calm one-word reply: “We do.”

For a moment, Ted Riel did not react. Even Lucretia did not react. A heartbeat later, they spoke in unison: “You have other evidence?!”

Duncan was silent for two or three seconds. Then he turned and looked into Lucretia’s eyes with a deep gaze: “The Moon.”

“That ‘stone sphere’…” Lucretia understood at once. “You mean, it is…”

“It is another fragment,” Duncan said with a slight nod. “It comes from another world—a world completely different from the homeland of this

sword. I don’t know what happened to it to make it what it is now, but I am certain it is…”

He suddenly stopped. It was as if some force was holding him back, not letting him speak that conclusion aloud. That blocking force surged through his mind like a roaring storm, a strong emotion pitted against his rational side.

Instinctively, he rejected that conclusion.

Lucretia sensed something. She looked at her Father with worry and confusion.

At last, Duncan spoke and finished the second half of the sentence: “…it is what remains of that world.”

In the end, reason beat emotion.

When he voiced that conclusion, he even felt a strange sense of “relief”.

In fact, when he first saw “the Moon” and later returned to the Vanished and spoke with Alice, he had already had this guess.

Since “the Moon” had appeared in this world, it was very likely that this world was his “homeland” after it had been twisted and warped beyond recognition.

But his homeland had no elves or Senkin. In the elves’ own legends, there were no humans. In the records of the city-states of the Boundless Sea, there was not even a word like “Earth”. The “torn history” that troubled so many scholars stood out all the more clearly in Duncan’s eyes.

So… how did this Boundless Sea really form?

The most likely answer was this: this place did contain his homeland, but only part of it.

To prove that guess, he only needed to find a second fragment from another world, something like “the Moon”.

He had not expected the second piece of evidence to appear so quickly and so directly.

Ted Riel and Lucretia exchanged a long look. After a brief hesitation, they understood that Duncan had no reason to deceive them in this matter.

So there had already been two pieces of evidence. No wonder this once greatest explorer could speak with such certainty and without doubt when he declared that the world today was a heap of ruins.

Lucretia did not ask where Duncan’s knowledge about “the Moon” came from.

Because she knew all the answers to such questions would in the end point toward Subspace. In one form or another, her Father had remade and transformed himself in that “deepest and darkest place”. Every piece of knowledge and every power he now held that she could not understand was part of those brands.

She should not keep tearing them open.

Ted Riel had been silent and deep in thought this whole time. Suddenly, he jerked his head up, as if he had sensed something.

The Truth Keeper quickly opened the heavy book in his hands and summoned the “stethoscope” from its pages. In one stride, he rushed to the side of the “living metal” on the central platform.

He pressed the stethoscope to the surface of the “living metal”. His face suddenly grew very grave.

A very weak, very slow heartbeat sounded in the room. With each beat, the sound became slower and fainter than before.

“They are dying.”

Ted Riel looked up, his gaze full of mixed feelings, as he spoke.

For the first time in his life, this Truth Keeper—whose duty was to protect the city-states—felt such complex emotions when facing an “alien thing” that had invaded the Mortal Realm.

Because he suddenly realized that this nameless lump, this “terrifying thing” that had frightened so many people in the market… was very likely a being just like humans, elves, and Senkin—a homeless one who had reached the Deep Sea era from the Great Annihilation.

And sadly, their world had been destroyed even more completely. That tiny fragment… was far from enough to keep them and their kind alive.

The Deep Sea era had left no place for homeless ones like them. Under some still-unknown mechanism, they had become what they were now, and they were about to die.

Nina and Shirley grabbed each other’s hands without thinking, not knowing what they could do. Lucretia could only watch with a complex gaze, because she knew this was already beyond what human power could change.

As the heartbeat grew slower and weaker, Duncan finally walked forward. He looked at the “living metal”, which no longer showed any hint of a human form, and another scene rose in his mind—

The stubborn warrior. The silent mage. The hunter and ranger who were always full of energy. The knights brimming with confidence. The pessimistic spirit medium. And that confident, proud, red-haired Groska woman…

They had set out on a bright, sunny afternoon, carrying the best swords and armor their kingdom had forged, the finest scrolls and sigils, and the king’s

blessing and trust. Together they had gone toward the distant wilds—just like in the ancient songs, where a band of heroes goes to save their world.

Duncan reached out and gently pressed his hand against the cold, hard “steel”.

“We are all the Lost Ones… Now, you are home.”

The deep, slow “thump” finally faded away. After one last, especially weak and sluggish beat, there was no more heartbeat in the room.

The final heartbeat sounded like a sigh.

Ted Riel turned around, as if announcing to the entire Deep Sea era:

“They are dead.”

Chapter 560: Two Questions

Now that mass of once-living “matter” had completely turned into a solid lump of metal.

To render harmless an anomaly that had already been registered for containment required a very complicated process. But for Ted Riel, a Truth Keeper of the Truth Academy, it was just routine work. He quickly brought in the person in charge of the underground archive and made proper arrangements.

Even though he felt a lot of emotion, and even though the past of that “living metal” had deeply moved him, as the Guardian of the City-State he had to handle this matter strictly according to the safety rules. Even if it really had once been a brave soul who tried to save the world, in this Deep Sea era that being had already become an “extraordinary intrusion” that might spread rot and corruption. What waited for this mass of matter was the high temperature of the steam core reactor boiler, followed by a strict series of purification, cutting, grinding, and sealing.

But from another angle, this was also a kind of burial. Ordinary people in this world went through the same thing. “Bodies” always had to be handled properly. The dead always had to make way for the living.

As for the longsword, it was the only material thing left from “that world” in the end. It had somehow returned to the state it was in when it was first forged. It was clearly a research sample of very high value.

Through it, scholars could build a deeper understanding of that world. Everything there had already vanished, but that understanding and memory still had meaning.

Duncan said: “I have no use for it.” He gladly agreed to Ted Riel’s request, handed the longsword to him, and spoke with some emotion: “Let the clever people uncover more of the secrets behind it. If you discover anything, I hope you can share it with me.”

“Of course,” Ted Riel said as he took the sword from Duncan with great solemnity. After a brief hesitation, he went on: “About what happened today and the information we now hold, I will gather the scholars of the Truth Academy to discuss it. If we run into new questions, we may still need your… help.”

“No problem,” Duncan said at once. He had no objection. He nodded, then pointed at Lucretia beside him: “You can contact me through Lucy. If I think of anything or discover something new, I will have her pass it on.”

There were still many things that needed to be explained and discussed. When the “Horizon Limit” of the Great Annihilation suddenly showed a crack before mortals, it would surely bring a huge shock to the academic world. The Four Gods Church would also pay attention and debate this matter. Whether they wanted to accept it or not, the Vanished and the master of the Vanished had already become an inescapable part of it.

As for Duncan, he did not care much about that. From his point of view, among the many pieces of information they had just obtained, there were still some key and unusual issues that Lucretia and Ted Riel had not noticed and, for now, could not even understand.

For example, the position of that “Deep Crimson” and how it behaved against all common sense.

If the information he had seen in the fragments of memory was real, and if that Templar Knight had not been wrong in his explanation of the Warrior, then the “red radiance” that destroyed the world should have been in outer space. It might have been a huge astronomical phenomenon crossing the galaxy, a band of light set against the background of the Starry Sky.

That raised a problem. A planet rotated. At least from the scenes in those memory fragments, the Warrior’s homeland also had normal sunrises and sunsets, with stars turning in the sky.

So in theory, that red band of light in outer space should have moved across the sky and risen and set with the other stars.

But why did that Deep Crimson always stay in one fixed place in the sky?

The Warrior and his companions had always searched for where the Deep Crimson fell, because in their eyes that red light stayed fixed in a certain spot in the sky. This kept them from noticing that the light had not fallen to the ground at all, but was actually set against the background of the Starry Sky.

That Templar Knight had raised this question at the end too. In a way, it was also the last and greatest “astronomical discovery” their civilization made before it perished.

Duncan guessed that that “light” was no longer just some visible physical object. The Deep Crimson was only the form it showed. Its true nature might already involve “destruction” and “distortion” at the level of the universe’s basic order, even its “rules”.

It might be a tear on a dimensional level, or some deeper and more complex phenomenon.

Yet Ted Riel and Lucretia were still unable to even notice this issue, let alone understand it in the short term. They did not even understand the

concept of a planet.

This could only be taken slowly. Even if Duncan wanted to explain it now, it would take a very, very long time.

The second question was: what exactly did the “worlds” in the World Aggregation Theory mean?

Was each “world” a different planet within the same universe, or was each a different universe when seen from a broader view?

Duncan raised his head and glanced at Ted Riel, who was still deep in thought, and at the longsword in Ted’s hand.

The two pieces of evidence, The Moon and the longsword, might support most of the descriptions in the World Aggregation Theory. But they were not enough to determine what “level” those “world fragments” that made up the Boundless Sea actually belonged to. In a broad sense, every planet could be called a world, and every universe could also be called a world.

For Duncan, the difference mattered.

But it was also a problem that the Truth Keeperand the Sea Witch could not understand or even sense right now. Duncan had no idea how he could explain these concepts to them in a short time.

Besides that, the secret of the Deep Crimson glow itself was even more worth attention. This was not the first time Duncan had “seen” that ominous radiance.

It had appeared in the vision of the New Hope’s crash, and in the oil painting in Alice’s mansion.

What on earth was that thing?

Lucretia noticed Duncan’s long silence and the change in his expression as he thought.

She grew a bit worried and asked: “Father, is there still something wrong?”

“…I have many questions and I need to sort them out when we get back,” Duncan said as he pulled himself from his thoughts and gently shook his head. “Let’s go back first. When I have some ideas, I will come to discuss them with you.”

Lucretia still looked worried, but from Duncan’s attitude she realized that these were probably more “problems that were hard to explain to others”.

In these few short days together, this was the first tacit understanding she had rebuilt with her Father.

So she only nodded and did not ask further.

“We should go,” Duncan said as he let out a soft breath. He glanced at Nina and Shirley, who still looked a bit uneasy, then looked at Ted Riel: “Send us back.”

The Truth Keeper nodded and once again summoned that “door” from his book. Then he walked through it together with Duncan and the others, returning to the academy near the Crown District.

“I will make some arrangements when I go back,” Ted Riel said before they parted. He glanced at Nina and Shirley, who stood beside Duncan. “No one will disturb you or your followers as you move around the city, but in return…”

“Don’t worry, we won’t cause any trouble,” Duncan cut him off with a friendly smile. “We are all law-abiding people who care about the city’s public order.”

The Truth Keeperstanding before him clearly froze for a moment.

Even Lucretia, standing to the side, was stunned.

Clearly, neither of them believed it.

But Ted Riel quickly controlled his expression again. He gave a stiff yet polite smile and said: “That would be… for the best.”

Then he paused and added very sincerely: “We should meet again when there is time. You may not remember me, but I still look forward to talking with you, about that… incredible ‘knowledge’.”

Duncan laughed and said: “Not many people dare talk about ‘knowledge’ with me. There are not many as brave as you. All right, then I’ll look forward to it.”

Lucretia looked at her Father, then at the Truth Keeperopposite them.

The witch suddenly felt a bit emotional.

It seemed that teaching was indeed very hard. This Truth Keeper would rather talk with her Father about Subspace than face a graduating class of students…

After a brief farewell, Duncan left the academy facility with Nina and Shirley, together with Lucretia.

They returned to the Witch’s mansion at 99 Crown Street.

“You can arrange things on your own. I’m going upstairs to rest. Unless it’s something special, don’t disturb me.”

After this simple order, Duncan ruffled Nina and Shirley’s hair, then went up the stairs to the second floor.

After a while, Shirley, who had been staring blankly, turned and whispered to Nina: “The Captain is not in a very good mood…”

“I don’t think you can describe it as just good or bad mood…” Nina hesitated, then whispered back with her own thoughts: “Uncle Duncan just has a lot on his mind. But actually, he’s already much better today than in

the past few days. He’s not so gloomy, he just seems to have a lot to think about.”

Shirley thought hard for a moment. She carefully glanced at Lucretia, who seemed lost in her own thoughts, then leaned closer to Nina and whispered: “I don’t think I understood the things the Captain talked about.”

“Honestly, I didn’t understand much either,” Nina said, sounding a bit embarrassed. “Maybe only people at Grand Scholar level can figure those things out…”

As soon as she finished, Lucretia suddenly broke her silence beside them: “Don’t worry about it. Even a Grand Scholar cannot fully understand them.”

Nina and Shirley both jumped in fright and stared blankly at the witch.

Lucretia shook her head at them, her expression very serious and stern.

“All of that ‘knowledge’ comes from Subspace,” she said. “My Father just ‘processed’ it so it is not as harmful. But it still is not something an ordinary person can easily understand.”

Chapter 561: Those Who Walk in the Wilderness

Because of the delay that afternoon, it was already close to dusk and time for dinner when Shirley and Nina returned to 99 Crown Street.

In this Elven city, there really were not many things that could be called normal food. But at least normal ingredients were always available. Lucretia's servants prepared a rich dinner for their guests, and Nina and Shirley finally ate food that "humans ought to eat".

But they did not eat this meal with easy hearts.

Everything they had seen and heard in that underground containment facility still left them dizzy even now. There were too many things they did not understand, too many that broke their view of the world: the Great Annihilation, the "black wall" at the start of history, those Doomsdays, those destroyed Old Worlds, and this "New World" born in the Deep Sea era…

For two young ladies who, strictly speaking, were still just "big children", all of this was a bit too complex and far ahead of them.

After they hurried through dinner, Shirley went back to her room. She sat in front of the table, dazing for a while, when she heard the soft clink of chains beside her. Dog poked his head out from the Shadows.

Shirley lowered her head and looked at this "friend" who had almost eaten her once but then raised her from childhood. She asked very seriously: "Did

you understand what the Captain said today? About all those pieces of different worlds piled together and turning into the Deep Sea era and so on…”

“I understood part of it,” Dog said. He lay down and gently rubbed his huge skull against Shirley’s knee. “But I didn’t understand the parts that went too far beyond common sense either.”

“I barely understood any of it,” Shirley said honestly. “Of course, I understood the sentences, but asking me to picture how those things actually happened is a bit too hard for my brain. In the end, why do we have to care how this world was born anyway?”

She spoke in confusion. She knew she sounded very shallow, but she never had anything to hide in front of Dog.

“You can live just fine without knowing anything,” she went on. “Anyway, the two of us lived like that for more than ten years…”

Dog suddenly lifted his head. His hollow eye sockets, full of blood-red light, stared straight into Shirley’s eyes. A low, hoarse voice came from his skeletal body: “You can live without knowing anything. But we still have to know that this living is not something we can take for granted. It is like this for an ordinary person, and it is also like this for the world itself.”

Dog’s sudden serious tone startled Shirley. She froze for a moment, then seemed to faintly grasp something and showed a thoughtful look.

“The world will not ‘live’ like this forever,” Dog said. He watched Shirley’s reaction, then laid his head down again and spoke in a muffled tone. “The Great Annihilation could destroy those Old Worlds, so the Deep Sea era we live in now can also be ended by another power. Ordinary people may stay ignorant of this until the day the end arrives. They will greet The End in a long dream of peace, like the people back in that Warrior’s homeland, those

citizens waiting in their kingdom for the heroes to return. Their ‘ignorance’ was their greatest divine blessing. For them, not knowing anything is enough to live, because they do not know how close death is.

“But Shirley, we are not the people who stayed in the kingdom—we are on the Vanished.

“You have seen those prophetic visions too. The Black Sun that descended on Pland. The Creator’s Blueprint that fell into a runaway state deep under Frostholm. The Boundless Sea when Vision 001 went dark. And those mumbling cultists… If you were someone ‘living in the kingdom’, you would never come into contact with these things.”

Dog rambled on. He shook his head, carefully hid away his fangs, and nudged Shirley’s knee with the tip of his nose.

“Shirley, you really can live without knowing anything. But now you already know. The Captain is worried about those ominous prophetic visions, and in fact, you are too. You just haven’t noticed it yourself.”

Shirley fell quiet. She sat still in the chair for a long time before reaching out to rest her hand on Dog’s skull. Her voice held a little unease: “Dog, are we people walking in the wilderness… like that Warrior? Are we also trudging toward Doomsday?”

“We walk toward Doomsday, and Doomsday walks toward us. ‘Awareness’ goes both ways,” Dog said. “When we know it exists, there is no difference between the two. The only question is… in what way and at what time it will catch up with us. I think this is also what the Captain is worried about.”

“…Dog, how do you understand this so well? This… feeling?”

The blood-red light in Dog’s eye sockets slowly dimmed and brightened: “Because I once felt something similar. When you were very, very small.”

He lifted his head and looked into Shirley’s eyes.

His voice was very soft, just like many years ago, when he tried to calm a frightened little girl to sleep on a stormy night—

“At the very beginning, you were a little creature I could not understand at all. You were so small, so weak. Your arms looked like thin sticks that could be broken with ease. Even though you had a symbiotic pact with a demon, you seemed so fragile that you could die at any moment…

“Every day, every second, I worried that this ‘death’ would come. I did not understand your breathing. I did not understand your heartbeat. I did not know how humans stayed alive. I only learned that you needed to look for food after you went hungry for several days. As a Abyssal demon, I was not yet used to ‘thinking’ about things back then, and you also… did not talk to me much at that time.

“So I always felt that you might die at any time, anywhere, because of something I still could not understand. Your breathing, your heartbeat, the flow of your blood—these strange ‘phenomena’ were, in my eyes, very fragile ‘temporary balances’. If any link stopped, you would leave me. That is why, when you woke up as a child, you always saw me feeling around and watching by your side. I had to check your breathing and heartbeat, to see whether you had already died.

“That worry is very similar to what the Captain feels now.”

Dog paused for a moment. He raised his head to look toward the second floor, then quickly drew his gaze back.

“I cannot compare myself with the Captain, and I should not guess at his thoughts. But today, in his eyes, I felt that same familiar… worry. This Boundless Sea that looks so vast is, to him, probably like you were to me many years ago—a small and weak ‘strange thing’. He does not know how it survives. He only knows it could die at any time.”

Dog had rambled for a long time and finally grew quiet. But Shirley still stared at him blankly for a long time without making a sound.

“Why aren’t you saying anything?” Dog asked in confusion.

“You never… told me any of this before,” Shirley said, a little dazed. “So when I was little…”

“It’s all in the past,” Dog said softly. “You survived. So all those worries and hardships back then are all ‘past’ now.”

Shirley pressed her lips together. She suddenly lifted her head in some worry and looked toward the second floor: “Dog, do you think… we’ll become like the Warrior and his companions in the story?”

“If I can choose, I don’t want us to be like them,” Dog said, shaking his head. “The Warrior could not stop the world’s Doomsday with just a steel sword. His hard march toward Doomsday was doomed to fail. But since it is the Captain leading us, we clearly have more than just a steel sword. So I am willing to be a bit more hopeful.”

“The Captain…” Shirley sighed. “I don’t even know what the Captain is doing right now… He didn’t even come down for dinner.”

“Are you going to bring him some food later and take a look at him?”

“Uh, better not—Alice will definitely go anyway.”

“That’s true.”

…

Looking out at the strange sky where daylight faded and the light dimmed, yet a faint layer of golden “sunlight” always filled the gaps between the tall buildings, Duncan let out a quiet breath and turned to switch on the room’s electric light.

Although that “sunlight” spreading through the streets gave Lightwind Harbor eternal “illumination”, after Vision 001 fell, the sunlight that spread over from the nearby sea and was blocked layer after layer by buildings could not light up the whole city. Deep inside the city-state, in places where the “sunlight” was blocked by rows of buildings, night could still be seen. There, people still needed the comfort of lamps.

The bright light drove back the gloom seeping in from all sides and seemed to add a bit of warmth to the room.

Outside the window, as Vision 001’s power faded, the pale crack of World’s Wound slowly appeared in the starless, moonless sky.

Its cold, pale glow spread through the night, yet was sliced into pieces by the “sunlight” lingering between the tall buildings. It formed a strange scene that no other city-state could see: World’s Wound and the sunlight appearing at the same time and crossing over each other.

Duncan stared at that gash-like “wound” in the sky, but in his mind he was still recalling the “memory visions” he had seen today.

He thought of that Deep Crimson that stretched across the sky like a huge scar.

What was that red light that spanned outer space and seemed to break the normal rules of physics?

That red light showed up no matter where he looked: in the vision of the New Hope’s crash, in the oil painting in Alice’s mansion, and in the Warrior’s homeland as it neared destruction.

There was no doubt that this red light was what scholars had been desperately searching for—the prime culprit that caused the Great Annihilation events, or at least the first sign of the Great Annihilation.

Letting his gaze rest on World's Wound, which also stretched across the sky, Duncan could not help but form a string of baseless "connections" in his heart—

Every Old World's destruction was accompanied by that huge red light. In the New World's Deep Sea era, the pale World's Wound hung high in the sky… Could there be some link between the two?

Was the World's Wound that shone over the night sky of the Boundless Sea an echo from an Old World's Doomsday? Or the remnant of that destructive power from the time of the Great Annihilation?

Duncan even had a more disturbing guess—

Had that destructive power never faded at all? Had it only gone into some kind of sleep, hanging over the world every night, and the so-called World's Wound was… only the form that "red light" took while it slept?

Could Vision 001's role be to periodically "hypnotize" that Doomsday Deep Crimson?

As this chain of guesses ran through his mind, Duncan's gaze grew more and more grave. Another question he had never thought of before suddenly surfaced in his heart.

In his own homeland, at least in the homeland of his memories… he had never seen that "red light".

Chapter 562: Another Fragment

Now, about that red light, Duncan already had two pieces of information:

First, before the Great Annihilation happened, before Doomsday fell upon those Old Worlds, a Deep Crimson like darkened blood would first appear in the sky. Its true body was projected somewhere deep in space, but the way it spread did not follow normal optical laws. No matter where you stood on the planet, you could see it at a fixed spot in the sky, and that spot did not change with the planet's rotation, as if it was drawn directly into the observer's vision or mind.

Second, that red light did not seem to show any direct destructive power. It was more like a phenomenon or feature that the universe itself produced during the Doomsday stage. It was a sign of collapse, not the collapse itself.

Third, Doomsday did not happen and end in an instant. The whole destruction process lasted for a period of time. As a world moved toward Doomsday, more and more strange phenomena appeared, and the rules kept twisting and mutating, until the underlying laws of the world could no longer bear that distortion. Because of this, the warrior and his companions had a last bit of time to start their journey, and the ship named the New Hope had enough time to lift off and depart.

For Duncan, this third point was especially important.

Doomsday did not happen in an instant. That meant people before Doomsday came had enough time to see that red light appear. Yet in his memory, he had never seen that streak of Deep Crimson.

He had been trapped in that “studio apartment” overnight. Before that, he had not seen any eerie red glow or any supernatural phenomenon, and after that he had not seen anything like it outside the window either…

Studio apartment?

Duncan’s memory suddenly stalled. After a moment, his brows slowly furrowed.

What exactly was that “studio apartment” of his?

All this time, he had thought that beyond the door of The Lost Ones lay his homeland. Outside his studio apartment, somewhere past that thick fog, there were still Earth’s busy crowds and calm, ordinary days. He had only been trapped in one room, separated from home by a single wall. But as the Moon appeared and the World Aggregation Theory kept being proven, that possibility had already dropped close to zero.

If he had had a faint feeling about this before, then now that feeling was clearly confirmed. He knew he could not go back.

But only now did he suddenly think of another question: if the other side of The Lost Ones’ door was not his homeland, then what, in essence, was that “studio apartment” that had been left behind?

Every time he “went back”… where exactly had he been going back to?

Duncan frowned hard. In the pale sunlight spreading outside the window, a long sword suddenly flashed in his mind, as well as that lump of living metal that had once been a “human”…

“Another piece of a world fragment…” He seemed to understand something, but his expression grew even more complicated. “What is the true nature of a world fragment, anyway?”

His thoughts became a mess. Memories and guesses rose and fell in his heart like small overlapping waves. Duncan paced slowly around the room to calm himself and sort his thoughts. Then he went back to the desk, pulled out a sheet of paper at random, and began to doodle on it. He had not meant to write or draw anything. He only traced lines over and over and smeared out shapes.

Then he suddenly stopped.

He looked at what he had drawn on the paper without thinking… a rough sketch of the Moon, outlined by messy strokes.

It was as if he were looking at a homeland that was right in front of him, yet one he could never return to.

Alice had said that if the symbol of home appeared in a place, then that place was home. She was not very clever, yet sometimes she could hit the heart of the problem with the simplest, purest thought. In a way, she had actually been right.

Home was right here, yet it was neither complete nor in the form Duncan knew. It was just a small fragment, and like that “warrior” who had turned into living metal, it had long since become something people could hardly understand.

Duncan unconsciously reached out a finger and touched the “Moon” on the paper, as if asking someone a question. He murmured softly: “Yes, what else could be left…”

The flapping of wings suddenly came from the side and broke Duncan’s daze. The chubby white dove dropped down from the top of a nearby wardrobe. It waddled over in front of Duncan, tilted its head, then lowered it and pecked hard at the Moon drawn on the paper with its beak.

It pecked a hole in the “Moon”, then lifted its head and squawked: “Raising my head, I gaze at the bright moon, raising my head, I gaze at the bright moon, raising my head…”

It suddenly stopped and kept tilting its head to look at Duncan.

Duncan also stared blankly at it. He looked at this dove that for some reason had suddenly “mutated” out of the spirit compass, this silly bird that had inexplicably followed him and was especially obedient and affectionate.

“AI-F, Ai-ee, Ai…” The dove flapped its wings, making loud and strange sounds. “AI-F…”

Duncan’s eyes suddenly widened. He reached out and grabbed AI-F’s body, but then quickly loosened his grip, as if afraid he might crush this small “creature” by accident. His breathing grew fast and his heart pounded. The dove in his palm tilted its head and looked at him with a dull expression.

Duncan finally opened his mouth: “…AI-F?”

The dove nodded. “Coo.”

Duncan hesitated for a moment and changed to a more accurate pronunciation: “…IE?”

The dove nodded quickly. “Coo.”

Duncan drew in a slow breath: “Internet Explorer…?”

The dove yanked out its wings with force and flapped even harder. At that moment it seemed more excited than ever, as if it had countless more excited words it wanted to say.

Yet after beating its wings hard for a long time, all it managed to make was loud, meaningless cooing.

Duncan gently let go and watched the fat dove happily walk back and forth on the desk. From time to time it stopped, tilted its head, and curiously watched its Master. In its little bean-like eyes there always seemed to flicker the light of a broken network connection and a frozen process. After a long time, he finally sighed softly, and a complicated smile appeared on his face.

The answer had been right in front of him from the beginning.

This silly bird was another tiny leftover fragment from his homeland that had suddenly gone dark.

He could not go back. He really could not go back.

Duncan sat quietly in the chair like a stone statue for a long time. He did not move, his face did not change, and he did not make a sound.

After who knew how long, he suddenly seemed to “come back to life”. He blinked, then began to think, or rather, forced himself to keep thinking:

If AI-F really was Internet Explorer, then what exactly was its “source” supposed to be? Those lines of code? The huge mass of data that had built up? The countless pieces of hardware that had once kept Internet Explorer running? Or the abstract idea behind that name?

Or… did it stand for a brief spark in the development of some civilization?

Maybe a world fragment did not have to match some physical object. It might even be a huge concept, a concept drawn out of the existence of the Mortal Realm.

Then did this guess also work the other way around?

Would the real, solid things that had once existed in those Old Worlds stay behind after the Great Annihilation and the coming of the Deep Sea age, only in the form of abstract concepts? Today, on this Boundless Sea, there were countless Anomaly Visions, and countless formless things and

forbidden knowledge born around those Anomaly Visions. What… had they once been?

And most crucial of all—what lay behind these changes? What were the true rules at work? What were the true nature of the Great Annihilation, and of that red light?

The new answers brought new questions. One question followed another, and it seemed they would never reach the end of the truth. Duncan felt that his thoughts had already reached a dead end. Until more clues appeared, he could not find any way to keep digging deeper.

Just then, a light knock sounded behind him, cutting off his deeper, heavier thoughts.

Duncan quickly came back to his senses. He felt the presence outside the door, so he let out a slow breath and calmed himself bit by bit: “Come in, Alice.”

The door opened and the doll-like young lady walked in. She held a large tray in her hands. On it was the dinner Duncan had missed.

“Captain,” Alice’s voice carried a hint of worry. “You did not eat dinner.”

For some reason, just seeing Alice’s face, which always seemed so free of any shadow, calmed Duncan’s tangled thoughts a lot.

He showed a small smile: “Thank you. Put it on the table.”

“Oh.” Alice set the tray down, then quickly added, “Do not worry, all of this is very normal food. It is made to suit an ordinary person’s taste. Nina said the ‘traditional dishes’ in this place are not for people to eat at all…”

As she spoke, she looked up again to study Duncan’s expression: “Are you all right?”

“I am fine now.” Duncan let out a long breath. He sorted out the questions he had just figured out, and a smile slowly appeared on his face. “It is true. With so much we have gained, I should be happy.”

“Oh.” Alice half understood and half did not, but she did feel that the captain’s mood had really improved a lot, so she was relieved. “They were a bit worried about you, so they asked me to come up and take a look. As long as you are fine.”

Duncan nodded lightly, but he suddenly felt a bit moved inside.

In this large house, there were indeed many people who were always worried about his “state”, and those worries all came with their own reasons. Perhaps only this doll, who usually looked so simple and silly, worried about him without a single trace of anything mixed in.

If he had to name another, Nina might be one too.

With that feeling in his heart, Duncan smiled and shook his head, then suddenly thought of something else.

“Alice.” He turned his gaze and looked into the doll’s eyes. “I need your help with something.”

Alice did not even think: “Ah? Sure!”

Duncan nodded. He reached into his pocket and took out the brass key he always carried with him.

“Alice, I want to use this key one more time.”

“All right!”

Chapter 563: Another Visit to the Garden

As always, Alice trusted the captain's words without question. She did not even get curious about why Duncan suddenly wanted to use that key again, and happily agreed.

But Duncan still explained it carefully to this doll: "I am going to enter that 'Alice Manor' again to confirm some guesses about the Old World."

Alice nodded hard. She did not really understand what the "Old World" in the captain's mouth was, but she knew it was something very serious.

Because they had already done this once, she quickly found a comfortable, steady place to sit this time. Then she turned around and exposed the Keyhole on her back.

"I actually talked it over with Nina before and asked her to change the back of my clothes to see if she could make a hole around the Keyhole," the doll said happily as she waited for the captain to wind her up. "But she was worried that sand and dust and other things would get into my Keyhole… I think she worries too much. It is not like I roll around on the ground. How would sand get into my Keyhole?"

"Better keep it covered most of the time," Duncan said casually. "No one knows if this delicate structure is fragile. If something gets in and jams it, I would have no idea how to fix it."

“Miss Lucretia might be able to fix it. She was the one who fixed Lunie… But you are right, it is still better to be careful. It took a long time to fix Lunie’s head…”

The silver-haired doll muttered on, talking about these things that would sound far too eerie and strange to other people as if she were chatting about everyday life. Duncan could not help but show a faint smile as he listened. Then he smiled and shook his head, picked up that strange brass key, and, just like last time, carefully inserted it into Alice’s Keyhole.

The familiar click sounded. The key began to turn on its own. Duncan steadied himself a little. In the next second, he felt the light and shadows before his eyes change. His senses quickly shifted and reshaped.

A moment later, he opened his eyes in the dark and let his five senses get used to the change in environment. When the scene before him settled, that strange “garden” under the cartoon sky, lush and green, appeared in front of him once more.

The silver-haired doll who looked exactly like Alice still leaned quietly against the pillar in the center of the garden, sleeping among the vines and thorns. The drawing board in the doll’s hands was also just as before. Its position and shape had not changed at all.

Duncan blinked. He did not rush to move at once. Instead, he carefully checked the surroundings and compared them with the scene in his memory.

Half a minute later, he was sure there was no Anomaly around. Everything stayed the same as when he left. He even had a feeling that while he had been away, time in this “manor” had stopped, and only when he returned did time here start moving again.

…This was likely not an illusion.

Duncan remembered what that strange “headless Butler” had once told him about the special rules of time in Alice Manor, and fell into thought.

After thinking for a moment, he raised his head and looked up at the “sky” above the garden.

The last time he came here, most of his attention had been drawn by the many strange scenes in the manor. His head had been full of questions. His limited focus had been scattered in all directions. So even though the sky over this garden had caught his eye, he had not looked very closely at those eerie cartoon drawings.

This time, he looked very carefully.

Clouds that looked as if they had been drawn with a child’s crayon floated against a pale blue sky. Exaggerated lines of sunlight cut through the clouds. The “Sun” painted in yellow paint was just as he had seen last time, giving off light and warmth and keeping the garden full of life.

It still brimmed with childlike fun, and yet that childlike fun overflowed with weirdness.

Duncan suddenly narrowed his eyes a little.

He studied that yellow Sun closely. This time, he finally noticed a detail he had missed before.

Around that scribbled Sun, there were no rune rings at all!

“No wonder… no wonder I felt something was off last time but could not tell what…”

Duncan muttered, and his expression changed slightly. He finally knew what had made the sky in this strange drawing feel so wrong. It was a normal Sun. The brushstrokes were abstract and simple, but it was without a doubt the Sun he was familiar with.

But it was exactly because he was too used to it that he had failed to notice this obvious Anomaly at a quick glance last time. If natives like Morris or Vanna came here, they would probably feel something was wrong at first sight.

Duncan's brows slowly drew together. Now that he had confirmed that the sky had a normal Sun, it felt as if one corner of the secrets hidden in this "Alice Manor" was being quietly lifted.

On the Boundless Sea, the Sun was an artificial heavenly body with twin rune rings. This was common knowledge. From the start of the Deep Sea era to now, across ten thousand years, this fact had never changed. No one in the world knew what the real Sun looked like. Even those Suntists who claimed to worship the true Sun god only drew a twisted, terrifying Elder God when they preached.

Then who had left this normal Sun, or rather this original Sun, inside Alice Manor?

This doll called "Alice" had only come into being after Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm fell into the Deep Sea. So why did the depths of Alice Manor, which was linked to her, record the image of the Sun from before the Great Annihilation?

And if he also thought about what the World Aggregation Theory guessed about the Great Annihilation, that the Deep Sea age had been piled up and reshaped from the remains of countless Old Worlds, then this original Sun recorded in Alice Manor… should belong to which Old World?

Did it stand for some star in some Old World? Or was it only an abstract symbol?

For some reason, what came to Duncan's mind at that moment was that plump dove.

He frowned deeply and shook his head, over and over trying to rearrange the tangled information in his mind. Suddenly another clue rose to the surface of his thoughts.

Alice’s birth.

Her appearance had indeed been copied from Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm. But her original body, the spirit coffin, had also been a flawed replica of the “Alice Guillotine”. Facts had proven that for the maker of Anomaly 099, the source and process of the copy itself did not matter. Whether it was a great human being or a hard block of wood, it was only the first raw material. The one that truly mattered was the maker itself.

It was the faulty replica of the Abyssal Lord that had created Anomaly 099.

Then could he think of it this way: this so-called “Alice Manor” was also a creation of the faulty replica of the Abyssal Lord. And if he took it further, even a faulty replica of the Abyssal Lord should still hold a great amount of information from the original body. Then some things in this Alice Manor might trace their source all the way back to that Elder God who remained in the Abyssal Deep seas.

Duncan lifted his head and once more carefully studied that abstract, simple Sun, along with the clouds and sunlight around it.

…Were these doodle-like images part of the memories the Abyssal Lord had let slip by accident, or some kind of message it was consciously sending out?

The more Duncan thought about it, the more he felt this was very likely. There was one point that was beyond doubt:

The real form of the original Sun had only existed at time nodes before the Great Annihilation. The secrets of this Alice Manor should also go back to before that time. From all he knew so far, only the Four Gods and those

strange, mysterious Elder Gods in the deep layers of the world might know something about the world before the Great Annihilation.

Duncan's heart stirred. He lowered his head and saw the drawing board in the doll's hands.

After a brief pause, he bent down and carefully moved around the thorns, then slowly drew the drawing board out of the doll's hands.

On the front of the drawing board, the eerie whirlpool, twisted stars, and ominous dark red light were still painted there. On the back, along the frame, the familiar words were still carved:

"…The messenger brought news from afar. The chosen clan picked up the lost Ancient Star and forged it into a crown of divine blessing—the third Long Night came to an end."

The chosen clan picked up the lost Ancient Star and forged it into a crown of divine blessing.

Duncan's gaze stayed on this line for a long time.

It was describing how the ancient Critt clan, under the guidance of the Crawling King, had built Vision 001 and raised it into the sky.

When he had first entered this garden and seen these words, he had not been able to understand what the line meant.

But now he suddenly understood.

He thought of that ten meter wide Moon, a "piece" that had fallen off the rune rings of Vision 001.

The rune rings that bound the Sun could be seen as a shining crown.

And that Moon, twisted and compressed by some unknown force… naturally fit the description of a lost Ancient Star.

Some faint sounds suddenly came from the depths of the garden and startled Duncan out of his thoughts.

He jerked his head up and looked toward the source of the sound.

There were only lush plants over there. Between the thick bushes and the shade of the short trees lay dim shadows.

But Duncan was sure he really had heard something.

This was the deepest part of Alice Manor. According to the headless Butler, even the high-ranking servants of the manor did not have the right to step in here as they pleased. Only Mistress Alice and the one called the “Gardener” could come here, but that Gardener seemed to have stopped appearing a long time ago.

Intruders? Or had that Gardener come back?

Duncan slowly furrowed his brow. He slipped the drawing board back into the doll’s arms and carefully walked toward that patch of thick bushes.

“Rustle… rustle…”

The faint sounds came again from some shadow.

Suddenly, something flickered at the edge of his vision.

A streak of shadow, like a slick and eerie tentacle, was sliding and wriggling through the darkness at the edge of the garden!

Chapter 564: A Quick and Hasty Exchange

In the deepest part of Alice’s Mansion, at the edge of this eerie garden, in the shadows between the lush bushes and low trees, twisted tendrils crawled and wandered, as if covered in fine metallic scales.

The faint rustling sound came again from another direction. Out of the corner of his eye, he saw another dark tendril, a limb like some kind of soft-bodied creature, slide through the gaps in the shrubs. It shook the branches, rubbed against the rough soil, and made a soft, scratching sound.

That faint rustling almost sounded like a call.

Duncan instantly spread out his senses, carefully watching for any movement in the garden. At the same time he locked onto the direction where one of the tendrils had just vanished and walked that way.

Behind him, under his feet, pale green spirit form flames spread with his steps, leaving a faint path of fire. The flames quietly seeped along the cracks in the ground, bit by bit reaching deeper into the garden.

This was “Alice’s Mansion”, very likely a crucial part of Alice’s “soul”. Duncan would not casually set such a place on fire. But now something strange had appeared deep in the garden, and he had to prepare some countermeasures. If some dangerous thing had really invaded this garden, he needed a way to deal with the intruders without damaging the mansion itself.

With wary thoughts turning in his mind, Duncan followed the rustling and slowly reached a place far from the “sleeping doll”, at the edge of the mansion’s garden. After he passed several shrubs and a few small unknown trees, he noticed the light around him had dimmed. The glow from the “scribbled Sun” in the sky seemed unable to reach this far. Under the cover of the plants, the gloom was like dusk.

In this dusk-like light, he saw a clump of plants in front of him suddenly shake. Then a tendril slowly lifted from within and swayed gently before his eyes.

There was no hiding, no tricks. This tendril seemed to have invited Duncan here on purpose, and now it showed itself openly.

Duncan stared in surprise at this bizarre “limb”-

The tendril was dark in color. Its surface had fine patterns that looked like tiny metal scales. Between the rough, complicated ridges he could faintly see pale blue lines. Those lines felt very familiar to him, as if…

As if they were the markings on the surface of that Elder Gods tendril under Frostholm, in the depths of the Deep Sea.

A limb of the Abyssal Lord?!

Duncan’s heart gave a sudden jolt as he realized where that sense of familiarity came from. At the very moment he thought of the “Abyssal Lord”, the blindly swaying tendril in midair suddenly shivered, as if some vast and distant will had finally connected to this piece of flesh.

It bent toward Duncan. With a strange, low hum, the end of the tendril slowly opened. From within, an “eyeball” like an irregular crystal appeared, shining with a cold blue light, and it fixed a gaze on Duncan’s eyes.

A deep, murky voice suddenly sounded, without any trace of emotion or gender. It was as if it rang directly inside his mind.

The voice said: “Hello, Flame Usurper. I have something to say to you.”

Duncan jumped in shock. He frowned tightly and stared at the tendril in front of him: “Abyssal Lord? The Crawling King? LH-01?”

“All of them. But now listen to me,” the tendril trembled, as if already bearing a load far beyond its limit. The voice it carried grew quickly deeper and distorted. It sped up its speech: “My chance to communicate with you is extremely limited. I will only pass on the necessary information now. Whether you can understand it or not, remember this:

“The designed lifespan of ?#%?# is only eight thousand years. Now it is running in overload. We have not received the signal from outside &*%? within the time limit…

“This is the final Cycle Reset. After this cycle, ?*??# will not regenerate.

“Preserve the fallen ?#&** fragments. If nothing can be undone, use them to extend the lifespan of each Node city as much as possible. Stay alive. Survival is the First Directive.

“We do not know what you can do, but you woke at the Cycle’s End. That must mean something.

“We firmly believe that you, and we, are not alone.

“The necessary information has been delivered. If there is a chance, I hope to… speak with you face to face… under more stable conditions…”

The trembling of the tendril quickly weakened. A pale, dying color began to spread over its fine, metallic scales. Duncan could clearly feel the voice in his mind pulling away and fading. He did not understand the exact principle or process, but it was obvious that the Elder God called the “Abyssal Lord” had slipped through some loophole, or used some outside power, to force a link with him – and now this very limited connection was about to break.

Duncan had no time to be curious or to think deeply about the flood of information. By sheer reason, he chose to quickly force himself to remember everything first. Only after the other side finished talking would he have time to turn his mind and think about what he had just heard.

The first thing he noticed was those few “noises”. When this Elder God spoke to him, several key pieces of information – clearly important nouns – had turned into sharp, chaotic sounds in his ears.

It was as if the “meaning” in those syllables had been filtered out by something, or as if the sense those syllables carried lay beyond what this communication could hold, so it could not be delivered to his ears at all.

But this was clearly not the time to dig into those “noises”.

The Elder God’s whisper was about to fade. Only the last thin thread of its connection with him remained. Duncan looked up and saw cracks spreading all over the tendril’s surface. It might only last a few more seconds.

He made up his mind in an instant and used the last of the time to ask: “If I want to find you, how do I go to the Abyssal Deep in the Deep Sea?”

Going to the Abyssal Deep in the Deep Sea and speaking with the being face to face was without doubt the simplest and most effective way to solve all his questions.

The Elder God’s tendril was already growing stiff. Faded fragments fell from it like dust. The powerful, unspeakable will was slowly withdrawing from this fragile vessel. Yet before its link with the Mortal Realm fully broke, it still did its best to hold on to that last bit of connection and sent one final low murmur into Duncan’s mind –

“I do not know.”

Duncan: “…?”

He finally understood how the people around him felt when a single sentence from him crashed their brains.

He really had not expected the Abyssal Lord to give him such an answer!

But he only froze for a moment before another faint, low whisper sounded in his mind –

“Try catching a few Annihilators…”

“Huh?” Duncan did not react at once. “Aren’t they your believers?”

But no voice answered his question. The Elder God’s murmurs to him finally broke off completely. With a series of cracking sounds, the tendril that had borne too much power collapsed at last. It turned into dust and fragments that fell to the ground, then rose as thin blue smoke and faded away.

The rustling sounds around the edge of the mansion garden also stopped at the same time. The unnatural gloom under the trees faded with them.

Duncan stood quietly before the bushes for a while longer. Only after several minutes passed did he frown, shake his head, and pull himself out of his thoughts.

Everything that had just happened still felt like a dream. An Elder God called the “Abyssal Lord” had simply appeared right in front of him, rattled off a pile of things at high speed, and then left just as fast. Forget Lightwind Harbor – something like that would shake the entire Boundless Sea.

Yet when it happened to him… it somehow did not feel that shocking?

Duncan turned and looked back at the lush “mansion garden” not far away under the daylight, and at the silver-haired doll sleeping quietly in the sunlight clearing at its center.

Anomaly 099, born from the Abyssal Lord's "copy" ability, and "Alice's Mansion", which was tightly bound to Alice – when it came down to it, this whole "mansion" already had countless ties to that Elder God in the Abyssal Deep of the Deep Sea. It was even very likely that the Elder God had shaped it on purpose as a vessel to send information outward.

So it was not unimaginable to see a projection of the Abyssal Lord's power in the deepest part of this garden.

Duncan was thinking about something else –

The Abyssal Lord's attitude, or rather its "state", did not seem quite like he had expected. It still kept its reason, though it seemed to be under some extreme restriction. Its attitude was friendly, not the pure urge to destroy that people imagined.

But these "differences" did not mean much to Duncan. After all, very few people in this world had truly come into contact with the so-called "Elder Gods". Information built on imagination was never reliable. On top of that, different people might see very different faces of an Elder God. The friendly, harmless good Neighbor in his own eyes would still look a bit unspeakable to an ordinary person. After living in this world for so long, Duncan at least had that much self-awareness.

What mattered most was still the "information" that Elder God had given him.

Duncan replayed those words over and over in his mind. They seemed to carry an enormous amount of meaning.

Some thing had been designed to last only eight thousand years, and now it was running in overload.

The "we" the Abyssal Lord spoke of seemed to have been waiting all this time for a signal to return from somewhere, but it had still not received that

reply.

It had also mentioned a Cycle Reset… what did that mean?

He, this “Flame Usurper”, had awakened at the Cycle’s End – what did that mean?

And then there was preserving the fallen fragments, using them to extend the life of the Node cities…

As he pondered, Duncan’s expression grew more and more serious.

Chapter 565: The Foreign Object

For Duncan, the easiest part to guess in the rush of information from the Abyssal Lord was actually the very first line – that something designed to last only eight thousand years was now running in overload.

The first thing that came to his mind was the Sun, now hanging high above the Boundless Sea yet already showing constant faults, even starting to drop parts. That was the first Vision, built in the Ancient Kingdom Era of Critt by the Critt clan under the lead of the Abyssal Lord.

The Sun had been running for ten thousand years. If its original designed lifespan had really been only eight thousand… then its current unsettling state now had an explanation.

From there, the thought spread further. The Abyssal Lord had also mentioned that “they” had been waiting, within this limit, for a signal sent back from “somewhere”, but it had still not arrived. Who did this “they” refer to? And this “somewhere” – that short burst of noise – what place did it name?

“We did not receive the signal from outside &*%? within the time limit…”

Duncan recalled the exact words he had heard from that Elder God and, together with the description in The Blasphemous Tome, he could boldly guess that the “we” it spoke of meant the ancient Elder Kings – that is, the old ones that included today’s four True Gods, as well as the other Elder Gods and lost deities. This single piece of information alone was enough to overturn the world.

The four True Gods and the “evil Elder Gods” recognized by the world were all waiting together for something, even sharing a common goal. If the Vanna of back then heard this, she would probably leap out swinging on the spot.

But what Duncan cared more about was the second half of that sentence: “the signal from outside &*%?”… what exactly was that short burst of noise?

If he connected it to the earlier fact that Vision 001 – the Sun – had also turned into a short burst of noise in the Abyssal Lord’s mouth, could he take it that this short noise here also stood for something similar in nature and rank to Vision 001? Or that there was some important similarity between them?

What were the traits of Vision 001? Its age? That it was a creation of an Elder God of extremely high mystery? Its vast scale that could affect the entire world? Its suspected link to the “Black Sun”? Or…

That some of its “parts” contained key structures from the Old World, such as those “Lost Stars”…

Then could the short noise inside “the signal from outside &*%?” also be related to the Old World?

Duncan raised a hand and gently rubbed his slightly aching forehead. Then he stopped and looked thoughtfully at his own hands.

Flame Usurper… this was not the first time he had heard “someone” call him that.

That “Black Sun” had called him this, and now the “Abyssal Lord” did the same. Their biggest common point was their rank as Elder Gods – that is, both were members of the ancient Elder Kings.

But from the Abyssal Lord's attitude, it seemed it only knew the name or concept of "Flame Usurper" and not its exact abilities or nature. The only useful detail it had revealed was that the Flame Usurper had awakened at the "Cycle's End"…

Then what about the other ancient Elder Kings? The Storm Goddess, the Everburning Ember, the God of Wisdom… these deities that still kept close ties with the mortal world – would they know more?

Duncan shook his head and sighed softly with a helpless look.

It was one thing for this world to be full of mysteries, but he himself was just as wrapped in them. What was worse, those "Elder Gods" and "True Gods" knew even more about it than he did, which was naturally frustrating. Even more frustrating was that their "network" was bad – getting in touch with them was purely a matter of luck…

As for what this so-called "Cycle's End" was supposed to be, Duncan had no clue at all and no energy left to think about it.

He strolled along the path at the edge of the garden and returned to the abrupt stone pillar. There he stood quietly, casting his gaze at the silver-haired doll sleeping in the brambles.

Whether the Abyssal Lord had built this Alice's Mansion, or whether the mansion had come first and the Lord later used it to form a link with the Mortal Realm, one thing was beyond doubt: the doll sleeping here and the "Alice" in the Mortal Realm were inseparable.

Duncan walked to the side of the sleeping doll and took out the clockwork key he carried with him. As long as he wound this key on the doll, he could return to the Mortal Realm.

But at that moment, a new idea rose in his mind.

Duncan quietly put the key away and turned to walk toward the gate at the garden's exit.

Following the route in his memory, he passed through the dense, gloomy trees and flowerbeds and came again to the garden gate with its gorgeous stained glass and intricate wrought-iron patterns.

The gate was half open. From the direction of the mansion hall he could faintly hear voices, footsteps, and the soft, broken music of a ball that seemed to never end.

He pushed the door open. The long, shadowy corridor beyond was empty.

But as soon as Duncan stepped into the corridor, the ghostly, headless Butler suddenly came into view – as if the headless Butler had been standing there in the shadows a few meters away from the start.

"Ah, the Guest holding the key," the Butler came up warmly, a muffled, deep voice sounding from his chest. "Have you greeted the Mistress?"

Duncan glanced at this frightening headless corpse and asked: "Have you been watching me?"

"I am only always waiting for the Guest's call – and you were only gone for a short while, so I have been waiting here," the headless Butler bent slightly, his tone as polite and proper as ever. "May I ask what you require next?"

Only gone for a short while?

Duncan frowned a little and remembered the strange idea of "time" in the mansion that the Butler had mentioned last time.

So that meant… just as no matter how long he spent in this mansion, only a moment passed when he returned to the Mortal Realm, no matter how long

he moved around in the Mortal Realm after leaving here, it was also only a moment for the servants in the mansion?

This mansion did not simply have time frozen. Its timeline ran independently of the Mortal Realm?

What kind of process lay behind that?

A flood of questions rose again in his heart, but Duncan's face did not change. He only nodded slightly to the Butler in front of him and casually asked: "During this 'short while' I was gone, has anything changed in the mansion?"

"Everything is as always, Guest," the Butler answered at once. "The mansion rarely changes. From the time I first had memory, it has always looked like this."

Duncan gave a quiet "mm" and then asked, as if in passing: "Before me, did any other Guest ever enter that garden?"

"Other Guests?" The Butler seemed puzzled for a moment, then quickly replied: "Of course not. You know this: only the Mistress and the Gardener may enter the garden area. Aside from them, it is open only to a Guest holding the key. Why do you suddenly ask?"

Duncan did not answer him. Instead, he asked at once: "That 'Gardener' you mentioned – what does he look like?"

"The Gardener… no one knows what the Gardener looks like," the Butler grew more and more hesitant. It seemed he had never answered such "detailed questions" for anyone before, so each step of his thinking became slower and harder. "The Gardener stopped appearing a long time ago. When the garden no longer needed pruning, he returned to the place where he should be… The Gardener is different from the ordinary servants. His task is to make sure the environment is comfortable when the Mistress rests and

that she is not disturbed. Beyond that, he does not need to be responsible for anything in the mansion, and he does not need… to speak with me…”

“It seems that even you, ‘the Butler’, do not know much about this mansion,” Duncan said calmly, casting his gaze on the “headless corpse” before him. “Then have you heard this name?”

“A name? Please speak.”

“The Abyssal Lord, the Crawling King, LH-01 – he may go by any of these three names. Have you heard of him?”

The Butler fell silent for a few seconds, as if thinking carefully.

Then an apologetic answer came from his chest: “I am sorry, Guest. I have no impression.”

The Butler’s tone was very sincere.

Duncan could not read any expression from a body without a head. The posture of this headless corpse was as precise as a machine and revealed no emotional change at all, so he could only choose to believe the answer for now.

“All right. Thank you for your answer.”

The headless Butler bent slightly: “I hope that was of help to you…”

He suddenly stopped. As if hearing some urgent sound, he straightened up at once and turned in another direction.

Almost at the same time, Duncan felt a change in the mood of the mansion. A sense of tension and panic seemed to suddenly spread through the air, and in the empty corridor countless hurried footsteps and whispers rang out at once!

He turned at once to the headless Butler: “What has happened?”

“A foreign object has invaded, Guest. Please excuse me,” the Butler said quickly, then turned and walked toward the other end of the corridor, looking unusually rushed.

A foreign object had invaded?

Duncan froze for a second at the phrase. Before he could react, the Butler had already walked off on his own. Seeing this, Duncan hesitated for a moment, then hurried to follow.

The Butler walked quickly ahead, turning slightly as if to glance at the Guest following behind, but making no move to stop him.

Seeing this, Duncan relaxed and hurried after the Butler, passing through the corridor, up the stairs from the first floor, and into the second-floor hallway that led to the “bedrooms”.

Countless hazy servants emerged from the air. Headless footmen and maids had already gathered in the hallway. These “lost souls” who lived in Alice’s Mansion whispered to each other, their voices a low buzz with no clear words, while a very real sense of unease filled the air.

Duncan already knew this route. He remembered that the end of this passage had once been the bedroom where the soul of Ray Nora, Queen of Frostholm, had slept. But now that the Queen’s soul had escaped, that room had been “torn” away from the main body of the mansion. At the end of the corridor there should be only a Great Hollow leading into an endless, dim space.

“Make way, make way! Do not touch the invading foreign object!” The Butler’s voice came from ahead as he walked forward, driving back the gathered footmen and maids. At this moment he showed some of the authority of the mansion’s administrator. “Where is the foreign object?”

The gathered servants all drew back, leaving an open space in the front part of the corridor.

Duncan looked over the headless Butler’s shoulder and finally saw the “foreign object” that had made the entire mansion so tense.

His expression froze at once.

It was a small bag of trash.

It looked very familiar.

Chapter 566: Foreign Object and Cleaner

It was a small bag of trash—a black trash bag, its mouth tied in a tight knot. On the side of the bag there was a tiny scuffed tear, and through that tear he could see a crushed paper cup.

Duncan stared blankly at that small, familiar bag of trash. For a moment his mind held nothing but confusion and endless questions. He had indeed guessed that the Great Hollow that had appeared inside Alice's mansion might change one day. When he heard the headless Butler mention a "foreign object intrusion" just now, he had also wondered what kind of strange and unspeakable thing might have entered the mansion. But this scene before his eyes… he had really never imagined it.

That bag of trash was the one he had thrown away—not long ago, after he vaguely realized that the barrier between him and his homeland might already be an uncrossable gulf. After he had carefully cleaned his little studio apartment, he had gathered up that bag of trash and thrown it into the black fog outside the door.

Now it appeared on the inner side of the Great Hollow inside Alice's mansion, in the form of an "intruding foreign object."

With a complicated and subtle feeling, Duncan took a step forward and walked toward that "intruding object."

At the end of the corridor, the huge Great Hollow left behind by the vanished room looked like a strange and terrifying abyss. The floor and

walls around the rim of the void were shattered, like twisted, jagged teeth. That black bag sat at the very edge of the broken floor. To be honest… Duncan even found the whole scene a little absurd.

Yet the servants in the mansion were extremely tense. The terrifying headless Butler even lost his composure a little when he saw Duncan walk forward and cried out: “Guest! Please do not go near there! It is very dangerous!”

“Dangerous?” Duncan did not even know what kind of expression he should make. He looked back at the Butler, the corner of his mouth twitching. “It is just a quiet pile of… discarded waste.”

Even so, the Butler and the servants still stood at least ten meters away as if facing a great enemy. Their buzzing, rumbling whispers were full of panic and fear. Although none of them had heads, Duncan still felt as if he could sense their confused, chaotic gaze—wanting to peek, yet shrinking away again and again because of fear.

It was as if… what they saw was not a harmless black bag, but some far more terrifying, far more unspeakable thing.

“Gue… Guest…” The headless Butler suddenly spoke, his voice low and trembling. “Do not be fooled by appearances. Please slowly keep your distance from it and move this way toward me. Be careful. Do not awaken these growing shadows…”

[Growing shadows?]

Duncan slightly frowned at once, as if confirming the guess that had just flashed through his mind for a moment—these servants were seeing something else?

He turned back and looked at that black bag at the edge of the broken floor.

In a certain instant, he saw the black plastic bag suddenly… “flicker.”

It was like the image on a monitor with a bad connection, or like a thin veil suddenly covered its surface. Duncan saw it flicker for a moment, and in that very brief change of light and shadow, it seemed… to turn into something else.

Duncan watched it with a calm gaze, as if waiting for it to change again. Then, the second flicker appeared.

This time, he caught the image that flashed by.

He saw a mass of swelling and shrinking shadows covering the floor not far away. The edges of the shadows trembled and shook, spreading out like countless sharp thorns. Some black substance was surging and seeping out from the center of the shadows. Countless eyes hid there, and countless mouths and tongues as well.

Yet as soon as he focused and looked carefully, that thing would immediately turn back into an ordinary pile of “discarded waste.” The eerie scene he glimpsed in that moment felt like nothing more than an illusion clinging to the shallow layers of his mind.

Duncan silently kept his gaze on the scene. Many guesses slowly settled in his heart. After an unknown time, he suddenly turned his head and asked the Butler: “Has there been a ‘foreign object intrusion’ here before?”

His voice sounded hoarse for no reason.

“Occasionally,” the Butler answered at once. “The mansion is closed off, but for some reason there are always things from ‘outside’ that connect to here. They… often bring great trouble.”

“‘Great trouble’?” Duncan frowned.

“Yes… Foreign objects do not belong to the mansion. To this place, they are like a disease. The invading matter causes some parts of the mansion to decay or twist, and it often takes a long time to recover…”

Duncan listened in silence, thought for a moment, then asked: “Then how do you deal with these foreign objects?”

“The mansion will ‘digest’ them on its own,” the Butler answered. “You only need to wait patiently nearby. The Cleaner should appear soon and should be able to properly handle the intruding foreign object.”

“The Cleaner?” Duncan’s tone held doubt.

“It is a part of the mansion, the oldest part. It is responsible for removing destructive ‘entities’ from the mansion. After that, the mansion will slowly return to the state it had before the intrusion… Ah, it has appeared, Guest, look—”

The Butler suddenly raised his arm and pointed at the floor not far away.

A mass of sludge-like stuff had appeared there at some unknown time and was slowly wriggling and spreading.

That “sludge” was dark in color, yet it had a metallic sheen. Its surface seemed mixed with countless crystal grains that, with each slow wriggle, endlessly refracted tiny points of light like starlight. It wriggled and spread, and as if it had a mind of its own, it slowly drew closer to the intruding “foreign object.”

Part of its edge deformed, stretching out into a tentacle-like extension. It used that structure to reach forward and probe, then slowly “covered” itself over that mass of growing shadows.

Duncan did not interrupt the process. He only stared hard at the scene, not letting a single detail slip.

The “waste” itself had no value to him. The key was why the waste had appeared here, the strange phenomena he had just observed, and the secrets hidden inside the mansion.

For him, the crucial piece of information had already appeared the moment he saw that small bag of trash inside the mansion.

The devouring was silent. The soft-bodied creature called the “Cleaner” soon completely covered the small bag of trash. In Duncan’s senses, he faintly felt that… something had vanished into that soft-bodied creature with its metallic sheen and tiny points of light.

The servants around them finally seemed to breathe out in relief.

But in the next second, Duncan saw the soft-bodied creature that had finished its devouring slowly turn its “body.” The edge of it rose and fell, and a bulging part that looked like a head was now firmly pointing this way.

The corridor instantly fell into tense silence. All the servants went rigid and quiet.

The Cleaner wriggled over. Under Duncan’s gaze, it approached like a mass of living sludge, seeming slow yet somehow fast.

He felt neither goodwill nor hostility from it.

Duncan slowly tensed up. ghostly green flame was already faintly flowing between his fingers. He stayed wary of this thing called the “Cleaner” and quickly thought about how he should deal with this mass of sludge and get out of here if it attacked, while damaging Alice’s mansion as little as possible.

However, the Cleaner stopped about two meters in front of him.

The mass of sludge stopped in front of Duncan. The soft structures that had spread around it slowly drew back bit by bit. It seemed to be carefully observing something. Duncan did not know if it was just his imagination…

He even felt as if he saw a confused emotion on a lump of “soft mud” that looked like a slime.

It had reason. It was trying to observe and understand the uninvited guest before it—but it could not.

It was as if the stranger's existence had already gone beyond some "built-in logic" of the mansion.

After a moment, the Cleaner seemed to break out of some kind of "dead loop." It suddenly shifted its attention away from Duncan, then turned as if nothing had happened and slowly wriggled toward a dark corner not far away.

Duncan blinked and stared at this scene in confusion. After a long moment, he turned his head to look at the Butler. "What does that mean? This 'Cleaner' does not welcome me?"

"This… I have not seen this either," the Butler said, sounding rather confused himself. "It is the first time I have seen the Cleaner have any extra activity after finishing its cleaning. Under normal conditions, it never lingers after it completes its work…"

Duncan frowned but did not ask further. Instead he turned and walked to the broken edge of the corridor, to the place where the Cleaner had just carried out its 'cleaning task.'

That small bag of "trash" had completely vanished. After undergoing strange and mysterious changes, it had been broken down and devoured by an equally strange and mysterious power, leaving not a single trace behind.

However, how had it come here?

Duncan stood on a broken floor tile at the edge of the corridor and leaned forward, looking out into the boundless darkness beyond.

For a moment, he even felt as if he were about to see his own "little room" out in that darkness—that it might be floating not far away, wrapped in a

mass of fog, just like… all those countless other Old World fragments in this world.

But he saw nothing. At the end of the corridor there was only endless darkness. The Great Hollow inside Alice's mansion did not seem to lead anywhere.

The pull of emotion almost made him step out into the void to search that darkness for so-called answers, but at the last moment, reason pulled him back.

He instinctively felt danger in that endless darkness. His intuition told him that it was not yet time—that he still could not return safely from that darkness.

"Guest?"

The voice of the headless Butler came from behind, cutting off Duncan's wild thoughts.

Duncan let out a soft breath and stepped back, returning to the relatively safe corridor.

"I should leave," he said softly. "Take me back to the garden."

In the Mortal Realm, Duncan suddenly blinked. His senses rushed back, and he fully woke up within two seconds.

Alice was still sitting properly in front of him.

In the Mortal Realm, only an instant had passed.

Chapter 567: veil of night Visions

Duncan rubbed his slightly sore forehead. As he put away The key, he recalled his experiences in the “mansion,” the message that the tentacle of that Elder God in the garden had passed to him, and the “intruding foreign object” that had appeared beside the hollow inside the mansion.

Alice soon noticed the captain’s “return.” As she pulled her clothes back down over her back, she turned her head curiously: “Captain, you’re back! Did you find the answers you wanted?”

“I got more information, but only more questions,” Duncan sighed softly. Looking at Alice’s always carefree, bright expression, he put away the chaos in his mind for now and let a small smile appear on his face. “But I have made a lot of progress—at least I have a new goal for the near future.”

Alice tilted her head a little: “A new goal?”

Duncan thought for a moment, then spoke in a calm tone: “First, we will catch a few Annihilators and see.”

Why had the “trash” he threw out of his studio apartment drifted to Alice’s mansion? Why had those things turned into growing shadows in the eyes of the mansion’s servants? What had really happened to the missing gardener in the mansion? What was the true nature of the Cleaner? For now, there were no answers to this chain of questions, and there was no good way to break through in the short term. But in another direction, the suggestion that the Abyssal Lord had given him was worth a try.

As for the state of Vision 001, the meaning behind those brief bursts of noise, the ancient Elder Kings, the truth of the Great Annihilation and the several Long Nights, and the meaning of the so?called cycle and the End… The Elder God that lurked in the Abyssal Deep Sea, clearly knew many secrets about all of this, and It was willing to reveal them to him, the one who carried the Flame Usurper.

So finding a way to build a connection with the Abyssal Deep Sea, had become the only clear path for now, just as the Abyssal Lord had personally suggested—to try catching a few Annihilators.

Still, whenever he thought of this "suggestion," Duncan could not help but feel a bit strange inside…

Alice did not think that much. She was simply happy that the captain had a new plan again. Even though she did not understand why, her face still showed eager expectation: "Okay, okay! Then when are we going to catch them? And where are we going to catch them?"

"…cultists are not jellyfish in the sea that you can just grab," Duncan rubbed his forehead. "Rest for today. Tomorrow I will talk this over properly with Vanna and Morris."

"…Oh," Alice nodded, but then another question popped up: "What is a jellyfish?"

"It is something that lives in… probably lives in the sea," the muscles in Duncan's face twitched as he gave this very odd explanation. "It looks half transparent. Some are poisonous, and some can be eaten."

"They can be eaten?" Duncan had only explained it offhand, but Alice's eyes lit up at once. "Then do they taste good?"

Duncan's face looked strange: "…You do not even have a digestive system. Why do you care about that?"

“I can cook them for you!” Alice said happily. “Captain, when we have time in the future, let’s go catch jellyfish together!”

He could feel the topic sliding into something strange, and he almost could not keep his expression under control. He hurriedly waved his hand to brush it off: “Alright, alright, I promise you. If we get the chance, we will catch some to eat…”

And so Alice left, happy and satisfied.

Duncan let out a gentle breath, shook his head with a touch of helplessness, and strolled to the window.

Judging by the time, veil of night had already descended now—Vision 001 had sunk below the sea’s surface several hours ago, and its power had faded from the world. The “rift” of the World’s Wound had appeared again in the sky, looking down coldly over the whole city.

But at the same time, there was still “sunlight” in the sky—that sunlight came from the “glowing geometric body” on the sea near the city-state. After its radiance spread out and was blocked again and again by the city’s buildings, only scattered beams that swept across the sky remained by the time they reached this area near the city center. Like light and shadow cast by blinds, those uneven beams swept over the high sky above the city, forming an eerie “view” that looked like some twisted form of dusk.

Under the “cutting” of that sunlight, the World’s Wound in the sky also appeared broken by light and shadow. It no longer stretched across the sky in one unbroken line, because wherever the sunlight swept, the World’s Wound became invisible. Only in the places that the sunlight could not reach could one see those pale, cold cracks, split into separate segments in the sky.

Duncan suddenly furrowed his brow. He realized a detail he had overlooked before and began to watch that thought?provoking “spectacle” in the sky with growing curiosity.

The glowing geometric body that had fallen onto the sea could not possibly project its light all the way up to where the World’s Wound lay—that high in the sky. Lucretia and the Scholars of Lightwind Harbor had already measured its range of light. It could more or less cover one city-state and part of the surrounding sea, but it could not reach the sky.

Yet what he saw now was that wherever the “beams of sunlight” swept across the sky above the city, the World’s Wound became invisible.

So… sunlight was actually not acting directly on the World’s Wound, but on the eyes of the “observers”?

The true role of Vision 001, the Sun, was not to suppress the World’s Wound, but to use some kind of covering or filtering method so that the world’s intelligent beings “could not perceive the World’s Wound” at all?!

Faintly, Duncan suddenly felt as if he had brushed against a key mechanism of Vision 001.

However, just as Duncan was about to follow this line of thought further, a strange sight that suddenly appeared at the edge of his vision broke his train of thought.

He immediately stepped forward, pushed open the window, leaned out, and looked toward a certain direction outside.

That was another street right next to the Crown Street district—he still clearly remembered that there were rows of rooftops and tall buildings there, and a distinctive spire that stood at the deepest part of the district.

Yet now, a lush forest shrouded in dusk appeared in his view.

Towering giant trees had suddenly risen from the city. The district's original buildings and spire had, at some unknown time, turned into the shapes of a forest. There were also high, arching structures that looked like huge vines spreading out from the forest, and some of them had even extended into the area of Crown Street!

Under the crisscrossing light of the "sunlight" and the World's Wound, those dark-colored vines crept and grew along the streets. They twined around the buildings by the road, climbed up the walls and high façades bit by bit, and wrapped around the streetlamps by the sidewalk, like tentacles stretching out from a nightmare, slowly stabbing into the Mortal Realm…

Duncan blinked and found that the "abnormality" in his field of view was still there. Under the crossing light of the sunlight and the World's Wound, it even seemed a bit more real than before.

Yet the city was still silent. Neither the distant districts nor the buildings right before his eyes that had already been wrapped in vines made a sound.

It seemed that no one had noticed this vast abnormality, even though a few nearby houses still had their lights on, showing that until just a moment ago there had clearly been people awake and moving about inside.

Duncan pulled his gaze back from the window, turned, and walked quickly toward the door. Before he could open it, hurried footsteps already sounded in the corridor outside, and the door was pushed open with a bang.

Alice, who had left just a short while ago, rushed back in. Panic was written clearly on her face: "Cap… Captain! Outside! Did you see outside…"

"I saw it," Duncan cut off the doll, who was so nervous she was stuttering. "It may be some kind of otherworld or illusion that covers a huge area, but it has not affected our house yet. Do not panic. Go call everyone together. We need to figure out what is happening."

Hearing this, Alice finally calmed down a little and nodded quickly. As she turned to leave the room, she spoke in a rush: “Oh… oh, right! Wait here. I will go look for the others!”

The doll left at a trot and soon vanished down the corridor outside. Duncan turned his head and looked again at the “strange scene” on the street outside.

The “forest” that covered a large part of the district was still there, lush under veil of night and as thick as shadows rising up. But the vines that had spread from the forest seemed to have stopped growing—many vines of different thicknesses had halted at the edge of Crown Street, with no sign of stretching further this way.

But that was only what he could see from here. He had no way of knowing what things looked like on the other side of that “forest.”

Just as Duncan began to worry whether other parts of the city had also changed, Alice’s hurried footsteps sounded again in the corridor, and her panicked voice reached his ears at the same time: “Captain, captain, captain! The… the others are all gone!”

This time Duncan finally froze: “All the others are gone?”

“Not a trace,” Alice ran over quickly, nodding in a hurry. She even clutched her head as if afraid it might fall off. “I just went to Nina and Shirley’s rooms. They were both gone. Miss Lucretia was gone too. No one answered when I knocked on the other doors. In the living room there were only those clockwork-driven servants—they were all standing still and not moving at all. It was so scary!”

Duncan’s gaze turned serious at once, but he still took a moment to calm the nervous Alice first. Only then did he narrow his eyes slightly and slowly spread out his senses.

He searched for the Marks on Vanna, Morris, and the others, trying to confirm their condition.

The Marks still existed, but their state… was very strange.

“Let us go downstairs and take a look,” Duncan opened his eyes, then beckoned to the cabinet beside him. The AI, who had been dozing on top of the cabinet, fluttered down onto his shoulder. Only then did he nod to Alice: “Stay close to me. Do not run around.”

Alice nodded at once: “O… okay, Captain!”

Chapter 568: A Large-Scale Otherworld?

The living room on the first floor was utterly silent, as quiet as the whole street outside. Everything still looked the way it had at nightfall, and the puppets and tin-man servants powered by clockwork and magic mechanisms stood quietly in every corner. It seemed that right up to the second before the “abnormality” appeared, they had still been carrying out their programmed cleaning orders.

Duncan led a very nervous Alice down the stairs. His gaze swept over the silent living room in the dim light. Their footsteps echoed in the dead stillness, making everything feel even more eerie.

Alice carefully clutched the captain’s clothes with one hand while turning her head to look to the side. A puppet shaped like a maid stood not far away, one hand resting on the stair rail. A moment ago this puppet had seemed to be polishing the banister. She still kept her upper body slightly bent forward, with a bucket at her feet. But like the other servants, she had gone still, and the ticking and gear-grinding sounds inside her no longer came.

Alice kept feeling that the puppet would suddenly turn its eyes toward her, just like in so many horror stories. The thought made her heart jump into her throat.

“So scary…” she muttered behind the captain. “There are dolls everywhere… They were fine in the daytime, but now they suddenly all

stopped moving, it’s really scary… But if they suddenly started moving again, that would be even scarier…”

Duncan silently turned his head and gave this silly doll a very strange look.

However, Alice did not notice at all, and did not feel she had said anything wrong.

Duncan shook his head and turned his attention back to the marks he had left on Morris, Vanna, and the others.

Those marks still shone in his senses, but their state was extremely strange. Sometimes he felt that the marks were clearly inside this house, even right beside him. The next second, they would suddenly appear very far away, like on the other side of the city-state. It was as if they were randomly teleporting.

This was the first time Duncan had seen anything like this.

He tried again to call to those distant marks directly in the spiritual world, to contact Nina and the others through them. But since he could never pin down the marks’ exact position and state, each attempt failed. At best he got a faint and meaningless “response” for a moment. That too was something he had never encountered before.

The good news was that he seemed to be slowly grasping the pattern of the marks’ strange state. Even if he could not locate them exactly, after some time to adjust he should still be able to link to them accurately. And on the other hand, as long as the marks were still there, he could be sure that the people carrying them were at least not in mortal danger, so there was no need to panic yet.

Duncan walked forward slowly while sensing and getting used to the distant marks’ condition. Just then, a faint clicking sound suddenly rang out in the living room, cutting off his and Alice’s movements at once.

Duncan snapped his head around toward the source of the sound.

The puppet maid that had been standing by the stair rail began to move bit by bit in the dark. Like a long-rusted machine, she stiffly turned her head. Her lifeless eyes slowly searched the living room for something.

For a moment Alice felt as if her head was going to pop off from fright: “Waaah! It really started moving!”

Duncan finally could not hold back: “You are a living doll yourself, so why are you scared of this?”

Alice froze for a second before she finally reacted: “Ah… right?”

Duncan ignored the embarrassing simpleton and turned his gaze to the puppet maid that was moving so stiffly. He looked especially calm, because from that puppet he already sensed a suddenly descended, familiar aura.

“Lucy? Is that you?” he asked, testing.

“Ah, you really are nearby…” The puppet finally focused her gaze accurately on Duncan. She worked her jaw, and a stiff, distorted voice came out: “But I still can’t see you. The quality of this temporary ‘medium’ is just awful. I really shouldn’t have skimped when I bought the housework doll. Long story short, how are things on your side? I sensed your call several times just now, but it always cut off instantly before I could answer…”

“Everything is fine here. It’s just that the house is completely empty and all of you are gone,” Duncan said at once. He briefly described the current situation on the street. “…That’s it. In short, from where I stand it looks like something went wrong on your side, while Alice and I were not affected.”

“It does seem that way,” after a few seconds’ delay, Lucretia’s voice came again from the puppet maid’s mouth. “The ones in trouble are probably us. You are still in the Mortal Realm, only seeing the Anomaly that has

appeared in the Mortal Realm. We… seem to have been dragged into the ‘inside’ of this Anomaly.”

“Are the others with you?” Duncan asked at once.

“No, it’s just me here. It looks like we have been scattered all over the place.”

“What’s around you?” Duncan asked again.

“Around me? Trees, vines, green that stretches out of sight. A forest,” Lucretia answered. “It looks very much like the forest we saw before in Taran Ael’s dream, but the atmosphere feels… not quite the same.”

…

The forest was shrouded in a dusk-like light. A strange, slightly gloomy sense of chaos seemed to wrap the whole world. The sunlight that filtered down through the layers of leaves between the crowns was dim and heavy, unable to dispel the gloom among the dense trees.

From far away there came now and then the cries of birds and beasts, or the sound of branches snapping. Other than that there were no obvious oddities, yet Lucretia, standing there, felt as if she could smell a strange… tension in the forest air.

It felt as if something was about to happen here.

She gripped a short wand in one hand, a wand that looked like a conductor’s baton. At the same time she maintained her link with a certain puppet she had made herself, and through it she reported to her distant Father what was happening here: “…There is a tense feeling all through the forest. It is oppressive and even carries an invisible fear. Yes, it is an emotion. As a witch, I can sense the ‘emotions’ drifting in the air. This place looks very similar to that dream of Taran Ael’s, but the sky has no invading

Sun spawn, and it seems there is something else deep in the forest… I am heading in that direction.

“The street blocks? I can’t see them from here. Everywhere within my sight is trees. The view is limited in this dense forest, but I’m sure it covers far more than one or two blocks. The range of this ‘otherworld’ is very large. What you see ‘over there’ should only be a small portion of it leaking into the Mortal Realm.”

Lucretia suddenly stopped. She listened carefully to the voice from far away, then nodded lightly a moment later: “Yes, I also suspect this is still that ‘dream’ – the one those Annihilators called the ‘Nameless One’s Dream’. But things are different from last time. Last time we entered the Nameless One’s Dream by using Taran Ael as a stepping stone. The information you got from those cultists said the same: to enter this dream, you must use an elf’s mind as a bridge. But this time everything happened so suddenly and strangely…”

She paused, then raised her wand and lightly tapped a vine in front of her. The vine immediately came to life, squirming as it grew forward and stretched out like a bridge across a deep gully ahead.

Lucretia walked forward along this vine bridge and went on: “…I still haven’t found that ‘bridge’, haven’t found who the Dreamer is. But according to the rules of dreams, I should already be very close to the Dreamer right now.”

She suddenly stopped.

Rustling footsteps appeared nearby. The sound came very abruptly, as if there had been no one there a second before, and then a person had just appeared out of thin air, stepping on dead branches and fallen leaves as they walked this way.

Lucretia focused at once. Before she even turned around she cast several protective spells on herself. Then she gripped her wand with one hand and looked toward the source of the sound.

But what appeared before her was neither a cultist invading the dream nor a twisted entity born from the dream.

A strange elf woman stood in the shade of a tree not far away, staring over with surprise and caution.

Lucretia's first thought was of the Dreamer who served as the "bridge" in this dream. But soon she realized what felt off about the strange elf in the distance. The woman wore a suit of light armor whose style did not match any city-state or era Lucretia knew. Pale-gold hair fell over her shoulders, braided with strange strands that glowed faint blue. In her hands she held a peculiar weapon like a mix of a spear and a poleaxe. Lucretia had never seen such gear in Lightwind Harbor, or anywhere else in the world.

While Lucretia was still in a daze, the elf woman with the long-handled weapon had already spoken in a stern, wary voice:

"Did you not receive the order to evacuate? Why are you still outside the Wall of Silence?"

Lucretia narrowed her eyes a little.

The situation… seemed to have become delicate.

…

Between the buildings, the "sunlight" and the cold glow from the World's Wound crossed and mingled. In this eerie night that belonged only to Lightwind Harbor, Duncan and Alice hurried across the street.

Alice was holding a puppet's head in her arms. Its mouth kept opening and closing.

Lucretia’s voice came from the puppet head’s mouth, reporting the latest progress “over there”:

“I’m moving together with this strange elf who suddenly appeared. She seems completely unaware that I’m not the same race as she is, and she lowered her guard very quickly… We’re heading for a place called the ‘Wall of Silence’…”

This scene was as strange as it could possibly be. A living doll was running in the veil of night, clutching another doll’s head in her arms. That head kept talking, its voice hoarse and distorted by its material. If any normal, sane person saw this, their sanity would probably drop on the spot.

However, Alice felt nothing odd about it at all.

She jogged along behind Duncan, and her expression even looked a little happy.

She was probably used to running around with a head in her arms… used to holding her own, so holding someone else’s was no different.

Chapter 569: Another Place in the Forest

In the forest shrouded in dusk-like light, Lucretia followed behind the elf woman with the strange long-handled weapon, trekking deeper and deeper into the dense woods.

The woman moved very fast. Even in a forest that was rugged and uneven, with vines everywhere and no paths at all, her footsteps were like she was running along a wide, smooth road. This extreme adaptation to the forest and her special way of moving made one think of some “classical arts” mentioned in ancient elf legends. In those stories, elves also lived in vast realms filled with forests. They could leap and move through the trees like a light wind, instead of being like modern elves, who had already forgotten many skills of living with nature in their high-rise city-states.

Lucretia of course could not keep up with such a pace. She knew that even without trying.

The young witch always refused outdoor activities. Even when she had to go out, she traveled using all kinds of spells. So the first time the elf woman left her behind, she decisively activated Phantom Wind, now and then turning herself into scattering scraps of paper to slip through the trees and keep up with the other’s speed. Father was not here anyway.

Her only worry was how the strange elf who had appeared in this “dream” would react after seeing all this. But in fact the other woman had no reaction at all when she saw Lucretia’s odd spells. Just like at the very

beginning, this elf had not realized that the “uninvited guest” before her was human. She simply invited Lucretia along as if she were one of her own kind, and wanted to take her to that place called the “Wall of Silence”.

Seeing this, vague guesses formed in Lucretia’s heart. So she intentionally did some even more obvious and out-of-place things to test her idea. She would simply stop now and then and use magic to cause quite a commotion, such as suddenly summoning huge flowering vines or making small explosions in the air.

The elf still showed no anomalous reaction. At most, when Lucretia deliberately slowed things down, she would stop and wait patiently for her to catch up.

Lucretia stopped her “tests” for the moment and focused on following the other woman. At the same time she controlled the distant puppet medium in her mind and described her situation to Duncan:

“Based on my tests, this elf is definitely not the Dreamer of this dream. She should be a ‘product’ of the dream, or one of its components. Her perception and behavior patterns are clearly limited. It looks like a kind of ‘Normalization Filter’. The anomalies of outsiders are being ‘normalized’ in her eyes. This normalization is probably meant to keep the dream stable.

“I haven’t done any more intense ‘tests’, so I don’t know the upper limit of this ‘normalization’. In theory, if my actions go too far, it might reset this elf’s perception, or it might cause a stronger ‘rejection’ from the dreamscape itself… I need to keep investigating right now, so I can’t take that risk…

“Ah, you’ve already entered the block where the ‘mutation’ happened? That’s great. Then I hope you can find the Dreamer from the Mortal Realm side. Once you lock onto the source of the dream, you should be able to intervene here directly as usual…”

“By the way, what’s your name?”

A voice suddenly came from ahead, cutting off Lucretia’s mental conversation with the distant side. The witch stopped at once and looked up.

The elf young lady with the poleaxe and the strange blue-glowing strands woven through her blond hair had turned her head and was looking over curiously.

“You can call me Lucretia,” Lucretia answered calmly. “Why did you suddenly decide to ask my name?”

“If one more person knows your name, that might be one more person who remembers you,” the elf said seriously from not far away. “My name is Celine. You need to remember it.”

Lucretia noticed the worry and tension in the other’s eyes.

Along the way, she had sensed this same worry in the strange elf more than once. The tense atmosphere had also filled the whole forest from the very start, like the “base color” of this dream itself.

After a slight hesitation, Lucretia asked: “What happened?”

Celine opened her mouth but could not get any words out, as if she did not know where to start, or felt that some things should not be told casually to an ordinary person. In the end she only shook her head lightly: “Don’t worry. Atlantis will protect us. Everything will be all right… Hurry up. It’s no longer safe outside the Wall of Silence. corruption could appear outside the wall at any time. Meeting a ranger like me is your good luck.”

corruption. Lucretia immediately noticed this special word and silently wrote it down in her mind. Then she followed Celine’s wind-like steps again, trekking toward the depths of the seemingly endless forest.

…

“Dog, do you hear anything?”

In the dark, endless, overgrown forest, Shirley suddenly frowned. She bent over to hide behind a clump of bushes while she watched her surroundings with care, and quietly asked Dog, who was hiding in the shadows.

Dog’s voice went straight into her mind: “The wind, the trees, the calls of birds I don’t know. On the surface, it’s all normal sound. But the mood is very strange, and it’s only been getting stranger. I don’t know how to describe it. It’s like… the environment itself is changing. The trees around us are no longer trees, but something that is slowly starting to show malice…”

Goosebumps rose all over Shirley. Her eyes showed her nerves as she looked around at the towering trees whose species she did not know. One of her arms was already slowly transforming, taking on traits of a Abyssal demon: “Dog, you’re kind of scaring me here. This place is nothing but trees everywhere, damn it…”

“You’re the one who asked me to say it. I’m just telling you what I ‘feel’,” Dog replied in a muffled tone. “I suggest you take it seriously. A Abyssal Hound’s senses are always sharp. This forest is slowly becoming wrong.”

“Even an idiot can tell this place is messed up…”

Shirley muttered under her breath and carefully left the bushes where she had just been hiding. She did not know what was changing here, but her instincts told her it was best not to stay in one place for too long.

As far as her eyes could see, there were plants everywhere. The dense, gloomy jungle was something a young lady who had been born and raised in the cramped, crowded Slum Quarter could never have imagined. Only recently had she heard about such places from the captain and the others in their conversations. She had not expected that just taking a little nap would

bring her here as well. If she was not mistaken, this should be the “Nameless One’s Dream” that the captain and Lucretia had both mentioned.

Feeling the creepy atmosphere around her, a hint of regret suddenly showed on Shirley’s face: “Maybe I shouldn’t have taken a nap while I was doing homework…”

“I don’t think your entering this weird ‘otherworld’ has anything to do with whether you took a nap while doing homework,” Dog’s shape slowly emerged from the shadows, condensing out of drifting smoke and dust. He paced beside Shirley, watching all around them, and kept grumbling: “But you’re not wrong about the rest. You really shouldn’t nap while doing homework.”

“It’s just that my head hurts every time I do math,” Shirley muttered, as if she wanted to talk about something ordinary to distract herself from the eerie mood here. “And I already know a lot of basic words. Why do I still have to learn math…”

Dog listened quietly beside her. He seemed to want to stay silent, but after a few seconds he still started nagging like always: “You still need to learn some math, even if it’s just for your own sake…”

Shirley pressed her lips together and could not help muttering: “Dog, why do you want me to learn these things so much… You seem more motivated than the captain…”

Dog did not speak for a while. When Shirley was almost ready to forget the topic, he suddenly said: “Do you still remember those seventy-two pesos?”

Shirley froze for a moment. After a while she slowly widened her eyes, as if she finally remembered something from a faded childhood memory.

A slightly complicated look came over her face. She spoke in a low, embarrassed voice: “You… still remember that. It was so long ago…”

“I’ll never forget. Some bastard, worth a thousand cuts, used a few pieces of paper scribbled with nonsense to cheat a child out of several days of pay from crawling through chimneys at the factory. If I had known how to read back then, you wouldn’t have gone hungry those days. If you had known how to read, you wouldn’t have had to crawl into those dark, dangerous chimneys at all. Being an apprentice in the pump room, copying down numbers, would have been better than that.”

Shirley fell silent.

After a long time she spoke again in a small voice: “But you can read now. You don’t just read. You can even keep up with Nina’s study pace…”

“What if I can’t stay with you forever?” Dog muttered.

Shirley was taken aback, at a loss for words for a moment. Then she spoke without thinking: “Then the captain…”

“The captain can’t protect you forever either. He’s a good man and he takes good care of you now, but Subspace is always unfathomable,” Dog said, shaking his head. “Shirley, you have to rely on yourself.”

Shirley lowered her head. After a few seconds she gently shook the chain linked to her arm: “Dog, what did you mean just now, when you said you might not be able to stay with me?”

“…Don’t think too much. I was just giving an example,” Dog sighed from deep in his throat. “I have no plans to leave you. It’s just that even I can’t be sure about the future. After all… I have a ‘heart’, and there has never been a Abyssal demon with a heart in this world before. No one knows what changes will happen to me. Maybe this ‘humanity’ will give me a lifespan limit like you humans. Maybe my reason will slowly wear away as the years go by. Maybe one day my ‘heart’ will just vanish again…”

“Dog,” Shirley suddenly cut him off. She stared wide-eyed and yanked hard on the chain in her hand. “You… stop talking.”

“All right, I’ll stop.”

Chapter 570: corruption and the Uninvited Guest

Shirley did not know if it was just her imagination, but ever since they entered this twisted, bizarre “forest”, Dog had seemed a bit sentimental. It sighed over many things and kept recalling old stories it had not mentioned in a long time. There were things even Shirley herself no longer remembered, yet Dog still remembered them clearly.

After hesitating for a moment, Shirley decided to say what she felt.

“Sentimental? Me?” Dog froze for a moment when it heard her, then grew puzzled. “Really? I’ve been sighing and reminiscing the whole time?”

“Yeah,” Shirley nodded again and again. “Normally you only bring up old stories once in a while, like some nagging old aunt, or lecture me with a string of reasons. But you’ve never been this… sentimental. It makes me feel weird and uncomfortable when I hear it.”

Dog slowly came to a stop. It finally faintly sensed the weak influence it was under. After thinking for a moment, it tilted its head. Its hollow, frightening eye sockets swept across the gloomy woods, the bloody glow within them slowly flickering.

“The forest is affecting us… it’s some kind of emotion,” it said in a deep voice. “A heavy, oppressive ‘mood’ lingers over the whole forest. It makes me brood and drift into wild thoughts, as if… as if I were submerged in a vast mind and being constantly disturbed by it…”

Shirley widened her eyes in alarm. “Huh… huh? You mean this forest is… thinking?! You’ve already been affected by it? Is it serious?”

Dog shook its head from side to side. “No, it isn’t really the forest. It’s this dream… Don’t forget its name, the Nameless One’s Dream. A dream is something made by a mind in the first place… But don’t worry, it’s not serious. The influence doesn’t seem targeted. It’s just passive interference from the environment. Shirley, are you all right?”

“I’m fine,” Shirley said, pointing at herself, though her face looked a little confused. “Yeah, if even you got affected, how come nothing happened to me… Maybe it’s because I don’t think too much about things?”

“If only it were that simple,” Dog muttered under its breath. “Don’t let your guard down. The subtle changes are the most dangerous. The more you feel fine, the easier it is for something to go wrong. If you suddenly feel low, or nervous and panicky, you must tell me at once.”

“Mm,” Shirley nodded quickly. Then she frowned, looking uneasily at the forest that seemed to stretch on forever. She spoke in a low voice. “Say… when do you think the Captain will find us? We can’t be unlucky enough to stay trapped here forever, right?”

“No, that won’t happen. Don’t overthink it,” Dog said at once. “Didn’t you already feel that faint call in your heart just now? That means the Captain already knows what’s going on. He must be trying to find a way. We just have to keep ourselves safe for now.”

“Oh.”

Shirley answered honestly, but just then, a strange sound came from not far away. It was a thick, sticky noise, like something was slowly melting and oozing down, and it cut off her talk with Dog.

The chilling sound made Shirley's hair stand on end at once. She yanked hard on the black chain beside her. "Dog! This time you heard—"

"I heard it. It's close. Something is—"

Dog spoke quickly and had already turned its head toward the direction of the strange noise. Almost at the same time, a scene beyond understanding appeared in its and Shirley's sight—

A patch of shrubs suddenly began to grow wildly. Large masses of pitch-black matter gushed out from between the thick leaves, and in the blink of an eye they formed countless limbs that flailed and writhed in the air. At the ends of those limbs, fine cracks opened up, like dense rows of eyes.

The towering giant tree beside them, on the other hand, seemed to "melt" as it toppled with a string of strange noises. Its thick trunk flowed down like sludge. The canopy that had once blocked out the sky lost its support, yet instead of falling, it slowly grew toward the heavens. In a twisted shimmer like unreal flames, it was stretched and warped into countless pale, drifting flakes.

The ground heaved, as if it had suddenly turned into a layer of soft, sticky skin, as if something terrible was crawling through the soil and about to break out…

The next second, all kinds of terrifying sounds burst out. Illusory crackling, the wet squelch of things writhing, and hissing full of noise filled every direction in an instant. The mutated trees spread in the blink of an eye to every place they could see. Everything before their eyes seemed to suddenly come alive, and in its mad, twisted growth it took on the shape of the deep layers of a nightmare!

Everything was mutating. Everything was warping. Everything was pushing against the edge of sense and reason. Right before Shirley and Dog, the

dream surged. Dark, malicious things finally crawled out of the earth.

They were flowing shadows, and in those shadows lay shapes and things that could not be described in words. It was as if countless eyes and rows of fangs were piled up in that writhing, surging sludge. Shirley only took one look at them, and at once realized there was only one thing she should do.

“Run!”

She only had time to shout this once. Before the words even fell, she had already turned and darted off, running toward a direction that still looked relatively “stable”. The rough forest ground rolled and bucked under her feet. Every step she took felt as if she were stepping on cotton, or on the skin of some soft-bodied creature. The touch that came back was disgusting and terrifying.

The body strengthened by her symbiotic pact with the Abyssal demons burst out its full power at that moment. She felt she had never run this fast in her life!

The fierce black chain went taut in an instant. Shirley yanked Dog straight up into the air, and it bobbed up and down above the ground as she ran.

Shirley kept dragging Dog as she sprinted through the forest, trying to escape. But after she had run for a while, she found the time to look back and saw that the surging nightmare was still chasing them. So she raised her voice and shouted again: “Switch!”

Before the word even finished, she swung the chain in her hand forward with all her strength and flung Dog straight ahead—

Before it landed, Dog had already adjusted its posture. It hit the ground on all four paws, steady and firm, and without any pause it used the force of that throw to keep on sprinting forward.

Now it was Shirley’s turn to fly through the air.

Even after several relays like this, the ever-mutating, twisted, nightmare "forest" still chased behind them, like a nightmare shadow they could never shake off.

It even gave Shirley a terrifying illusion, as if the whole forest had come alive with raging malice and had decided to swallow her and Dog whole, hunting them from every direction.

But luckily, just when she felt she really could not escape, the "nightmare" that had been chasing and spreading behind them suddenly slowed down.

Just as suddenly as it had begun, the forest's twisted corruption stopped without any warning—

Still dragging Dog, Shirley ran on for dozens more meters before she finally realized it. She skidded to a stop in a mess beside a fallen giant tree, then turned her head. She stared wide-eyed at the distant dark corruption that had stopped spreading, panting hard as she said: "Dog… huh… it stopped over there…"

Dog's huge body, driven by inertia, whistled past her and crashed headfirst into a nearby pile of boulders.

After a thunderous boom, Dog struggled out of the rocks, shaking its head as it shouted: "What?!"

"Ah…" Shirley glanced at Dog in embarrassment, then pointed at the dark, twisted area in the distance that had stopped spreading. "It suddenly stopped over there."

"Hold on a second…" Dog muttered. It ran to the side of the rocks, opened its mouth, and retched: "Bleh—"

With the sound of foul, corrosive stuff eating into dirt and stone, the dizzy Abyssal Hound finally finished throwing up. Then it shook its head, slowly

walked back to Shirley's side, and looked up at the place where the horrible corruption had stopped.

A sharp "boundary" now lay across the forest. On this side of the line, the plants were still lush and full of life. On the other side, however, everything had become a chilling, unspeakable place filled with strange, twisted shadows and writhing matter.

Countless living vines and flowing shadows that had crawled out of the soil still writhed slowly within that dark region. Even though they no longer spread this way, just looking at them filled one with a deep, gut-level dread.

Shirley did not even dare look that way for long. She barely managed to steady her breathing, and her voice still trembled. "What… what the hell is that?"

"I don't know… I'm no expert on dreams," Dog said, coming to stand beside her and staring at the distance with extreme caution. "But this might be what the Nameless One's Dream truly looks like. Some deadly thing is spreading in the depths of this dream. It's just that the dream is so large that last time the Captain and the others never ran into it—but we did."

"Why am I always the unlucky one…" Shirley muttered, frowning. But she soon shut her mouth and turned a wary gaze toward a certain direction.

Dog also drew back its gaze from the corrupted area at once. A low growl came from its throat as it stared hard at a patch of open ground a few meters away.

A strange presence was approaching.

They did not know how that unfamiliar presence had appeared, but clearly… someone was entering this dream.

Was it a friend or an enemy?

From that presence, Shirley and Dog both felt a certain… familiar yet troubling sense that made them wary and annoyed.

The next second, under their gaze, a hazy image suddenly appeared on that empty patch of ground. It was like a dream bubble slowly coming into focus, and within the illusion a human shape gradually took form.

A young man in a dark blue coat appeared on the open ground. He was tall and lean, with a harsh, gloomy face.

The instant the young man's figure appeared, both Shirley and Dog noticed a phantom of a black chain flash into view near his shoulder blades. At the end of the chain, the vague outline of some ominous bird-like shape showed for a moment.

Shirley's eyes changed slightly. She tightened her grip on the chain linking her to Dog without thinking.

The "uninvited guest" not far away reacted at once as well. Sensing the unfamiliar presence on the scene, he suddenly turned his gaze.

A girl in a black dress, standing beside a Abyssal Hound, came into his view.

He was startled for a moment, then frowned:

"…This area already has people in it?"

Chapter 571: The Spreading Depths

The tall, gloomy man opposite muttered to himself under his breath, and his one sentence made Shirley instantly hold back her urge to swing Dog at him.

She reacted at once. All the skills in reading faces and putting on an act that she had learned since she was little made her expression flawless in an instant. Looking at the man opposite her, she loosened Dog's chain a little and put on a puzzled and slightly nervous look. "Is something wrong?"

The gloomy man smoothed his brows when he heard her and waved a hand at Shirley. "Don't be nervous, fellow believer. We still don't fully understand all the rules of the Nameless One's Dream. It's normal for some deviations to appear when we enter the dreamwalking state. It's just that…"

He paused here, and a trace of doubt slowly appeared in his gaze toward Shirley. "I didn't expect such a young fellow believer to show up here. Are you really fine entering the Nameless One's Dream like this?"

"The connection with the Abyssal Deep has nothing to do with age," Shirley said at once. She shook the sturdy black chain in her hand, and Dog beside her cooperated by letting out a tame low growl. "I'm a veteran summoner. Don't be fooled by how I look."

"…All right, I was being rude," the Annihilator opposite her seemed to let go of his doubts. A stiff smile appeared on his harsh face. Then he raised his head to look around. His gaze quickly fell on the "border line" not far away,

and he grew thoughtful. “The corruption boundary… We are in luck. It looks like we are not far from that ‘wall’.”

Seeing his attention shift elsewhere, Shirley quietly let out a breath of relief. She also noted the strange terms he had let slip, like “corruption boundary” and “wall”. She kept her expression under control and memorized those words, then went on using the acting skills she had not used in a long time but still handled with ease. Casually, she said: “Just now that boundary was spreading like crazy. To be honest, it was pretty scary.”

“You ran into the corruption zone expanding?” The gloomy man raised an eyebrow. “Ah, that really does sound unlucky—but as the Nameless One’s Dream keeps developing, this will only happen more and more often. According to those ‘Preachers’, the corruption and collapse of this dream are bound to happen. That’s why we must find that Wall of Silence as soon as possible… We shouldn’t waste time.”

As he spoke, the Annihilator raised his right hand slightly. A black chain appeared in the air beside him, and the smoke and dust at its end gathered into a “Death-Omen Bird”, as if something had half rotted away. It was pieced together from bones and shadows.

This Abyssal demon let out a sharp, grating cry as soon as it appeared. Then it beat its tattered bone wings and flew up into the air, as if sensing some flow of breath within the dream. After a moment, it landed on its master’s shoulder. No one knew how this muddled, dim-witted demon communicated with its “master”, but the latter soon settled on a general direction and looked toward the depths of the forest. “Let’s head this way first.”

Shirley stayed quiet and, with Dog, simply followed the tall, gloomy cultist, walking with him toward the depths of the forest.

But beneath her calm surface, her mind was already racing. She thought about this man’s goal, thought about how to ask questions without arousing suspicion, thought about how to make herself act more like a normal Annihilator. At the same time, she also thought about how she should move to take this guy out at once if her disguise failed.

She felt her mind grow sharp again, as if, now that she finally did not have to think about all those sleep-inducing letters and numbers, all kinds of ideas had come back into her head.

She carefully controlled the distance between herself and the cultist—

She could not be too close. Too close would make him wary and suspicious.

She also could not be too far away. If she was too far, she would not be able to hit him with one swing of Dog. She had to keep him within one-dog throwing range.

“My name is Sarah. What’s yours?” After a few seconds of silence, Shirley made up a name for herself and asked.

She had grown up cheating and swindling in the Slum Quarter, so such little lies came easy to her.

“Richard,” the cultist walking ahead said without looking back. “The Holy Lord gave us a shortcut to the ‘essence’. Names aren’t that important, young fellow believer.”

“Oh… you’re right. I was just asking,” Shirley hurried to nod. Then, as if without thinking, she asked: “Are there many people who ‘came in’ this time?”

“There are more than a dozen other Church brothers and sisters acting with us. They come from different city-states—but I don’t know the details. The Saint above arranges everything. I’m the same as you, only carrying out the orders passed down by the envoy.”

“…Sigh, they think I’m young, so they never tell me anything. They just send me in to scout,” Shirley grumbled casually, her complaining tone sounding very real. “And right after I came in, I ran into the corruption zone expanding. I’m so unlucky today—thank goodness for the Holy Lord’s protection.”

The cultist who called himself Richard glanced back at her. He did not seem suspicious at all.

After all, the Abyssal Hound walking beside this girl was the strongest “proof of identity”. In this world, only Annihilators could form a symbiotic pact with Abyssal demons. As long as that identity was clear, she was definitely a “fellow believer”.

At most, she was just a fellow believer who lacked experience and asked too many questions.

Once Shirley realized this, she herself grew a bit bolder.

She began to make use of her image as “young and inexperienced”, dropping one roundabout question after another from time to time.

Dog’s slightly puzzled voice sounded in her mind. “Shirley, why do I feel like you’re actually pretty excited?”

“Of course I’m excited. I’m about to do something big!” Shirley kept chatting idly with the cultist ahead, her face calm, while she muttered to Dog in her heart. “If I can trick him into saying a few useful things, the Captain will definitely reward me later—maybe I won’t have to memorize vocabulary for a couple of days… Dog, Dog, do you think if I catch one alive and bring him back, he can cover my math homework?”

“How are you going to drag someone back out of a dream?”

“Ah… right. I forgot about that part.”

…

Deeper in the district, vines and giant trees that seemed to have grown and spread out from the dreamscape wrapped around and covered every building in sight. The whole block became a silent, shadowy, eerie forest.

Dark-colored vines climbed the high walls nearby. Fine thorns coiled around the lamp posts. Tall trees blocked the mouths of alleys, and their crowns covered the rooftops of the buildings. Some branches crisscrossed between the trunks and went straight through those dead-silent houses, as if fused with the solid cement walls. It created a strange scene where the forest and the city's buildings merged and twisted together in a warped symbiosis.

In this eerie, deathly still scene, the footsteps of Duncan and Alice sounded especially out of place. They even seemed like a ripping, discordant noise inside this "spreading dream", echoing along the empty street.

Duncan frowned, his gaze sweeping over the lifeless street before him.

The towering crowns of the trees blocked out the sky. Both the sunlight that usually spread in from the sea outside the city-state and the cold glow of the World's Wound that faintly appeared in the night were blocked by the thick plants over the district. The street lay in an unsettling gloom, and in that darkness, he and Alice had not seen a single person as they walked.

That was, of course, not normal.

The district was under curfew after nightfall, but even on a curfewed street they should still have seen patrolling Church guardians.

Yet there was no one at all—not only was the street empty, but when they passed some houses along the road, Duncan and Alice did not see any figures inside them either.

Some of those houses even still had their lights on. From the way things were set up, it looked as if someone had been moving around in the living room just a moment ago.

“We haven’t seen anyone in the part of the district covered by this ‘forest’, not on the streets and not inside the buildings,” Duncan said, turning his head toward the puppet head Alice was holding in her arms. “It’s like everyone has vanished, just like you did.”

“Like us?” Lucretia’s voice came from the puppet’s mouth, sounding a bit distorted. “Do you mean… everyone in the whole city has been shifted into this ‘dream’?”

“Hard to say, but at least in the places Alice and I have passed, the people are all gone,” Duncan shook his head. “Over there, have you run into anyone else who entered the dreamwalking state from the Mortal Realm?”

“No,” Lucretia answered at once. “I’m still moving together with this elf who calls herself ‘Celine’. We haven’t met anyone else along the way.”

Duncan listened quietly, then turned to look at Alice. “Can you see any ‘lines’ around here?”

“No,” Alice shook her head. “We haven’t seen any at all.”

Duncan nodded, his face dark.

The lines of spirit form could not hide from Alice’s eyes. No matter how clever the masking trick, as long as a “person” was still in the Mortal Realm, Alice would see the “lines” drifting in the air. But now even this doll said she saw nothing at all… That could only mean that, at least within the streets that had changed like this, the “people” really were gone.

This was not like what had happened before with Taran Ael, or with that elf maiden from Pland.

Although it still seemed that this incident was related to the Nameless One’s Dream, clearly… this time the dream’s scale and power had grown to an unimaginable level.

Duncan lifted his head and looked into the center of the altered district through the gloom.

Suddenly, a patch of shadows in that darkness caught his eye.

It was a structure that wound between the buildings, like a huge vine or some exposed root system stretching outward.

It lay there quietly in the dark, as silent as everything around it. Yet for some reason…

Duncan kept feeling that this huge “vine” was different from the rest.

Chapter 572: Unstable

With a strange sense of unease, Duncan led Alice at a quick pace to the side of the huge “vine” that lay quietly coiled between the shadows of the buildings.

It was even bigger than Duncan had imagined.

Even at its farthest, thinnest end, the vine’s diameter was greater than a person was tall. Its thicker “source” stretched down from a slope deep in the street, then seemed to melt straight into the night, vanishing into the dim distance. He could only see huge shapes rising and twisting between the buildings’ shadows, as if some much larger, more complete “body” still lay hidden there.

Yet that massive “body” was shrouded in a hazy blur. No matter how he looked, he could not see it clearly. Even the sunlight that fell through gaps in the high canopy seemed unable to pierce that misty layer.

Alice had never seen anything like this. She stared, stunned, clutching the puppet maid’s head in her arms. She widened her eyes, trying hard to see the vine’s “source” where it spread across the street. After a long time she finally spoke in a daze: “Captain… is this also a ‘plant’?”

Duncan did not answer. He kept watching the giant vine that almost blocked the street ahead. After a long time, he walked to its tip, bent down at its “tail”, and carefully reached out to touch its rough, hard surface with his fingertip.

Lucretia’s voice came from the puppet head in Alice’s arms: “Dad, did you find anything? Did you find the Dreamer?”

“We did not find the Dreamer, but we found a huge… vine,” Duncan said without looking up. “It looks very different from the other plants in the street. It is enormous, but it seems to be only a part of an even larger ‘plant’. I don’t know why, but I keep feeling this vine is… alive, or rather, active.”

He raised his head and let his gaze sweep over the towering tree shadows around the street.

Thick vegetation filled the whole block, yet all those plants felt dead to him, like empty illusions with no life. Only the huge vine in the middle of the street gave him a faint sense of a living thing.

After hesitating for a few seconds, Duncan took a slow breath and decided to try to make contact with this unusual vine.

A strand of ghostly green flame flowed around his fingertip like water, then quietly seeped into the vine. The firelight flashed once in the dimness and vanished.

He skillfully guided this thread of flame to spread through the “foreign object”. At the same time he told Alice to watch their surroundings. Then Duncan slowly closed his eyes. He began to feel the information the flame sent back to him, and tried to communicate with and understand this vine that seemed to spread out from some vast dream…

In the darkness, something seemed to rise and fall, gather and then fade away.

Duncan “opened” his eyes in the dark. Through this faint and blurry link, he tried his best to see the shapes that were forming and dissolving there.

Mist rose out of the darkness. Deep inside the fog, something was coming into view.

There really was something here!

Duncan's heart leaped. He moved at once toward that vague shape. He felt as if he had turned into a swift wind or a shadow, darting through the dark mist. As he drew closer, the hazy shape quickly grew larger in his view and slowly began to show more details.

He could not help picking up speed. The blurred details also sharpened in his eyes. Little by little, he began to make things out.

A tall, imposing bow. A dark-colored hull. Gunport covers lined up along the side. Complex masts and rigging. High above, sails that looked half transparent.

Duncan stopped in shock.

He raised his head in the dark and stared, dumbfounded, at the familiar sight at the end of the mist. He was looking at his… the Vanished.

…

Nina, who was moving carefully along a rough, hard forest path, suddenly stopped. She frowned and tilted her head, listening to the sounds coming from deep in the woods.

A moment later, she turned her head and said: "Mr. Morris, did you hear something?"

"It's the wind. It picked up all of a sudden, and the directions are all mixed… it doesn't sound normal," Morris said, his face growing more serious. He glanced at Nina beside him. "Go 'up' and take a look at what's happening in the distance. Don't stay in the sky too long. Be careful."

"Alright!"

Nina agreed at once. Then she suddenly turned into a leaping arc of flame and shot straight into the sky. The bright arc whirled quickly over the forest. Almost at the same time, the forest that had been formed by a dream reacted. The trees touched by the arc's light began to grow madly, creaking as they stretched toward the sky. The clouds high above also started to gather toward Nina and slowly formed a ring that closed in around her…

But Nina only circled in the sky for a few seconds. Before the forest's reaction grew more intense and dangerous, she quickly flew back down to Morris's side.

"That was scary… this place really doesn't welcome me…" she said, patting her chest with some lingering fear.

"Maybe your radiance is too strong for this 'other realm'," Morris said. "Most such realms will instinctively reject any invading power that can threaten them. What did you see in the distance?"

"Deep in the forest there's an area where something happened. It looked pitch-black. The trees and the ground there seemed rotten. But it's very far from us. In another direction I could see very tall, long shadows lined up together. They looked half transparent, like a curtain of light. Other than that, I didn't see anything…"

Nina spoke quickly about what she had seen in those few seconds she circled high above. She raised her hand and pointed out the rough directions as she talked. But halfway through her words, another gust of howling wind suddenly rose from deep in the forest. The chaotic wind tore through the trees, and the sudden creaking and snapping of the trunks around them cut her off.

The howling, chaotic wind seemed filled with countless vague roars. A strange tension and a feeling of rejection rushed over Nina and Morris at once.

It was as if this forest shaped by a dream was being hit by some great force from outside, as if everything here had suddenly become unstable.

The two of them glanced at each other without thinking. Right after that, they saw the giant trees in the distance start to sway and collapse like phantoms. Fine cracks quickly covered the sky. Light and shadow from the Mortal Realm seemed to shine in through those gaps. A feeling of about to wake sharply from a dream rose in their hearts.

At the same time, in another part of the deep forest, Shirley also heard the howling noise rushing in from far away. Right after that, the Annihilator walking ahead of her suddenly stopped.

Shirley's heart jumped at once, but she quickly kept her face calm and said: "Huh? What's going on?"

"The dream is losing stability. The operation is over. Everyone is to leave the Nameless One's dream," Richard said as he turned back. At last doubt showed on his face. "You didn't get the message?"

Shirley froze for a second, then quickly adjusted her expression. She put on an innocent, confused look. "I don't know, maybe I missed it by accident…"

"By accident?" The Annihilator who called himself Richard stared straight into Shirley's eyes. He seemed to finally notice the sense of wrongness this "young comrade" had given him along the way. A trace of wariness and doubt appeared in his eyes. "Comrade, I think I forgot to ask… which city-state in the Mortal Realm do you operate in?"

Shirley noticed the subtle change in his gaze at once. She was very sensitive to even the smallest hint of malice from strangers. Still, she kept her harmless look on her face. "I'm in the city-state of Morka. There are lots of elves there…"

“‘Comrade’,” Richard suddenly cut her off. His voice changed, as if some hidden syllables had slipped into his speech. He stared into Shirley’s eyes. With each movement of his mouth, some kind of tempting power seemed to spread. “We are forbidden to reveal our true locations in the Mortal Realm during an operation, even when we meet ‘our own’. What a pity…”

Malicious magic had quietly gathered in his mouth. The power of the Death-Omen Bird flowed along the symbiotic pact chain into the cultist’s body. He felt the spell lock onto the mind of the girl in front of him. She still did not seem to react at all and only stood there in a daze.

Seeing this, he became even more sure of his guess.

Someone who knew nothing about the spell’s power could not be a true child of the Abyssal Lord.

He did not know where she came from or how she had made such a convincing disguise. He did not know what was going on with that seemingly flawless “Abyssal Hound”. But there was no doubt this “comrade” was fake. Luckily, he had noticed in time, and the other side did not seem to have any combat experience.

It was time to say goodbye. No one could survive under the curse of the Death-Omen Bird…

It all happened in an instant. Richard’s flash of judgment and emotion, and the bright, happy smile that suddenly appeared on Shirley’s face, came almost at the same time.

Richard stared in shock as the girl across from him suddenly beamed at him. He had time for only that single moment of shock. He had no time to react or see clearly what was happening before the girl who called herself “Sarah” suddenly swung her arm up toward him, and a fierce black shape came crashing at his face.

With one sharp move, Shirley lifted Dog and brought him down. The chain howled as the dog smashed into the cultist’s head.

“See you the hell later!”

Chapter 573: Sailing in Darkness and Fog

With a loud bang, the Annihilator spat blood and flew more than ten meters away. He only stopped when he slammed into the trunk of a towering tree, then slid down like a torn sack.

The last look in his eyes was one of huge shock and confusion. Maybe in his life he had imagined all kinds of strong enemies and traps, but he probably never thought he would one day be sent flying by someone hitting him with a dog.

Shirley held Dog's chain and walked step by step to the cultist who could no longer move even a finger. She stopped at a relatively safe distance.

The cultist was still alive, or rather, in this "dream", a wound that would be fatal in the Mortal Realm did not seem enough to kill him. His head was almost smashed into his neck. Most of his joints bent at strange, terrible angles. Yet he was still alive, only too weak to move and able to stare this way with eyes full of hate and a little fear.

Shirley ignored his frightening stare. She lifted the chain in her hand a little, and Dog stepped forward, sticking close to the cultist's face.

"What are you…" The Annihilator forced the words out of his throat with difficulty. He looked at the fierce, terrifying Abyssal Hound drawing up beside him. A trace of fear finally broke through into his eyes. Not far away, the Death-Omen Bird that shared a symbiotic pact with him also struggled a few times, as if trying to resist, but soon fell quiet again because its partner

was so weak. That made his voice sound even more hollow and forced. “What are you going to do?!”

“This place is a dream. Once you’re back in the Mortal Realm, I won’t be able to catch you,” Shirley said as a slow smile spread across her face. She raised the arm that shared the symbiotic pact with the chain and gently rubbed the black links against her cheek. Her expression still looked harmless. “And if we meet when I’m not ready, it would be dangerous if I don’t notice you in time. So I need to leave a little mark…”

“A mark…?”

The Annihilator lying on the ground froze for a moment. The next second, he saw the Abyssal Hound beside him suddenly open its jaws. Its horrible bony fangs bit down without mercy. He had time for only one scream of terror before the pain almost tore his mind apart. One of his arms had already turned into bloody chunks in the hound’s mouth.

“I’ve memorized your scent. We’ll catch you in the Mortal Realm…” Dog lifted his head. His eye sockets glowed with blood-red light as he stared at the wailing Annihilator. A hoarse, low voice came from his ribcage. “We’ll bring you in alive. He will reward us…”

His cries cut off at once. The cultist’s eyes flew wide open. He stared fixedly at the savage Abyssal Hound in front of him, mouth gaping. He did not know whether he was more shocked that this Abyssal demon could speak, or at the huge fear and danger he felt in those last words. “He” will reward us… What were this strange girl and this strange demon? Who was the “He” they spoke of?

The next second, the Annihilator’s form began to blur and twist. In just a breath or two, his figure vanished into thin air before Shirley and Dog.

“He ran off after all,” Dog said, turning his head and shaking it from side to side. There was a hint of helplessness in his tone. “His allies in the Mortal Realm must have sensed something and yanked him away by force… we can’t stop this kind of transfer on the level of the mind.”

“It’s fine. Didn’t you memorize his scent?” Shirley waved her hand and then asked again with a serious look on her face. “Once we’re in the Mortal Realm, can you really find him?”

“As long as he isn’t too far away. If he happens to show up within my sensing range, I can definitely track him down,” Dog muttered. “Abyssal Hounds are the demons best at tracking. He can’t erase the mark I left.”

“Good,” Shirley breathed out in relief. “If we can really catch him alive, that would be great. Even if he’s only worth two test papers…”

Dog ignored the rest of Shirley’s muttering. He lifted his head. Chaotic wind and noise rushed through the forest from every direction. The trees in the distance were turning transparent and dim in large swaths. The signs that the dream was about to break apart were growing clearer.

Clearly, something was pushing on this dream. It was about to wake up.

…

In the darkness, some sounds seemed to drift over. They sounded like chaotic winds howling, snapping branches as they rushed through the woods. But when he listened more closely, they seemed almost like illusions.

Duncan had no attention left for the faint sounds from the dark. All of his focus was on the unbelievable scene before him.

It really was the Vanished. After he had spread his senses deep into the vine, he saw, at the center of this darkness and fog, that familiar ghost ship.

But… why? Why would the Vanished appear in this place?

Duncan moved closer and saw that the Vanished seemed to be floating on a pitch-black surface of water. Thick, inky darkness swallowed the lower half of the ship. On the tall deck above, the whole ship lay silent. No sound came from it.

After a brief pause, he “flew” up onto the Vanished’s deck.

In this darkness, he was moving only as a viewpoint, and that gave him plenty of freedom.

There was no one on the deck. Everywhere he looked he saw old, familiar sights.

Following the paths in his memory, Duncan slowly checked every feature on the deck and the nearby cabins.

Everything matched, down to the last detail.

But he knew this was not the real Vanished, nor some kind of projection of it. He did not feel the close bond that existed between himself and his ship. He did not feel any feedback from the flame.

This ship had been made by some other power.

Once more, faint wind and noise came from the dark, a little clearer than before.

Duncan paid some attention to the sounds coming from deep in the darkness. Then he went to the aft deck and stopped in front of the captain’s cabin door.

His gaze lifted and then froze.

There was a line of strange words carved on the doorframe: “May He wander in the dream.”

It was not “Door of the Lost Ones”?!

Duncan felt a jolt of shock. He clearly remembered that the words above the captain’s door should have been “Door of the Lost Ones”, and that this door was the only way to his little “bachelor apartment”… This Vanished that had appeared deep in the dark fog matched his memory in every way. Why was the writing above this door the only thing that was different?

He drew his eyes away from the frame and looked at the door itself. The next second, the door swung open without a sound, almost as if it were inviting him in.

The familiar captain’s cabin appeared before him. A dim yellow light shone inside. Every piece of furniture was in place, and Goathead stood at the edge of the chart table in the lamplight.

“Goathead?”

Duncan’s heart gave a sudden thump.

He remembered that when he had first stumbled into Subspace, the damaged Vanished on the Subspace side had not had Goathead. In his own bachelor apartment, the model of the Vanished had not had Goathead either.

Whether Goathead was present or not seemed to be a subtle but key point that set the different “versions” of the Vanished apart.

A stream of guesses and memories flashed through his mind as he stepped through the captain’s door. He walked carefully up to the chart table and looked at the black “wood carving” on its edge.

Goathead sat quietly on its base, motionless like a real wooden carving. It did not react at all to the captain’s approach.

Of course, that might also be because Duncan’s presence here was only that of a viewpoint, not a visible body.

Duncan did not try to disturb Goathead on the table. He kept watching carefully instead.

Soon, he noticed another wrong detail.

On the table lay the enchanted sea chart. It was supposed to be the chart that recorded the routes the Vanished had sailed, the known city-states and sea lanes on the Boundless Sea. But now it showed a scene Duncan had never seen before, a completely unfamiliar map.

It looked like a forest viewed from the air. In the tiny, almost three-dimensional image he could see rolling ridges, huge plant structures, and strange sites scattered through the dense woods like clusters of buildings. A translucent icon that stood for the Vanished floated over this miniature scene and was moving through the forest at an extremely slow speed.

Filled with shock, Duncan stared at the strange enchanted sea chart for a long time.

Of course he could not pull any useful information from such an unfamiliar map. But he remembered another strange enchanted sea chart he had seen on the damaged Vanished in Subspace.

On that Vanished sailing through Subspace, the enchanted sea chart had also shown an eerie scene. In some chaotic, shifted unknown sea, strange, jumbled sailing records lay everywhere.

Now he was looking at yet another unexplainable enchanted sea chart on this Vanished that had appeared in the dark fog. This time it even showed the ship sailing through a forest.

He could not stop a bizarre idea from rising in his heart.

Just how many different “versions” of the Vanished were sailing through different dimensions at the same time, recording different routes?

As this strange thought popped into Duncan’s mind, a faint creaking sound suddenly came from beside him and cut off his wild guess.

He instantly turned his gaze toward the source of the sound.

The black Goathead at the edge of the chart table was slowly turning its neck, bringing its gaze around to face him.

In its eyes, carved of black obsidian, a faint hint of awareness seemed to be forming.

The next second, Duncan heard a hoarse, low voice reach his ears.

“Who is there…”

Chapter 574: Waking from the Dream

The sudden voice from the Black Wooden Idol left Duncan stunned. He had not expected that, on this wrong and uncanny Vanished that felt like a mysterious vision, the strange Goathead in front of him would suddenly “come alive”. His gaze locked on the slowly moving “wood carving”, and a hint of wariness rose in his heart. Then he realized something:

The other side seemed unable to “see” him.

Right now he was only using the flames of his spirit form to build a link and “peek” into the depths of that huge vine. Only his thoughts were being sent here. He had not truly projected his power here, and of course he had not condensed a body in this place.

So the Goathead on the table must have only sensed a presence—and now it was starting to search for the source of that presence.

The unsettling Black Wooden Idol turned slowly. Faint creaks came from its wooden base. In the dead silence of the Vanished, in the dead silence of the captain’s cabin, those creaks sounded even more eerie. Its obsidian-carved black eyes swept several times across the spot where Duncan’s point of view hung. At last it stopped and let out a puzzled sound: “Is… someone there…”

Its voice was slow and low, like someone talking in their sleep.

From its reaction, Duncan at once noticed something odd. This Goathead did seem to have sensed something, but it had not recognized the presence as the “captain’s” aura?!

After a brief, heavy pause to think, Duncan made up his mind.

The link built through the flame strengthened at once. Power flowed here along the fire, and Duncan began to “lean” his will toward this strange space filled with darkness and thick fog, quickly condensing his form here.

He had to figure out what was going on with this Vanished sailing in the mist, and with this strange Goathead in front of him.

On the Vanished that sailed through darkness and fog, strands of ghostly green flame appeared here and there on the deck. In the dimly lit captain’s cabin, a wisp of spirit flame suddenly appeared in midair. It crackled as it spread, then quickly outlined a tall figure.

In almost an instant, Duncan’s link with this eerie dark space grew stronger. But in that same instant, he felt that this fog-filled space, and the Vanished under his feet, seemed to be… triggered. Everything around him suddenly turned vague and unreal. A delayed sense of rejection surged in from all directions. It was as if the dark fog was pushing back against his flame—or as if this strange place itself was quickly falling apart.

The sudden rejection caught Duncan off guard. This was the first time he had felt such an active pushback while using the spirit flame to probe an unknown thing.

He had used the spirit flame to probe many things in the past. He had used it on Alice’s spirit coffin, on that brass clockwork key, and on all kinds of extraordinary items seized from cultists. None of those things had ever reacted like this.

Could this strange space, and that huge “vine” that had appeared in the city, still be alive? Was there a powerful “mind” behind it?

The shocking guess surged through his thoughts, but this was clearly not the time to dig to the bottom. Duncan did not know how long he could keep this “link” to this place. He could only try to keep himself stable while striding toward the Goathead by the chart table.

The black wooden carving seemed to wake from a dream as well. It suddenly raised its head. Its gaze fell on Duncan—both the ghostly green flame and the tall figure had appeared in its eyes out of nowhere, like a bright light suddenly bursting into a peaceful and dark dream. In its startled, broken dream, it stared at the uninvited guest and said in a dazed voice: “Who are you?”

“Looks like you don’t know me.” Duncan was not surprised, since he had already noticed a few clues just now. While he did his best to keep his link to this place, he quickly sensed information about this Vanished and about the Goathead before him. He said: “I am Duncan Abnomar—what is your name?”

“Duncan… ah, that sounds a bit familiar…” The Goathead did not seem fully awake. Its voice drifted in and out, like someone slipping into Dreamwalking, and it did not answer Duncan’s question directly. “But I don’t remember… why are you here… why are we here…”

Duncan frowned.

He could already feel that this dark, fog-filled space was starting to crack and fall apart. The strong rejection was trying to push his flame out. The Goathead in front of him seemed stuck in a half-dreaming state and could not answer his questions at all.

After a brief thought, he stepped closer and pointed at the enchanted sea chart next to Goathead.

“Where is the Vanished sailing?”

It took a second or two before Goathead reacted. It slowly turned its neck, and its gaze landed on the “sea chart” that was currently showing a forest. After a long time, it murmured: “…Oh, good… so they’re still there…”

“They?” Duncan asked at once. “Who are they…”

But a sudden violent lurch and a low roar that seemed to sweep through the whole space cut off his words.

The rejection he faced here reached its peak. Every inch of space and time seemed to resist the spread of the spirit form’s fire. Soft crackling pops sounded in the air, like the flames were burning against an invisible barrier. Senses carried through the fire became suddenly blurred and slow.

Duncan lowered his head and saw that the projection he had condensed, his avatar form, was growing more and more indistinct. His link to this place seemed about to be severed.

He knew he could force more power together and use the fire of his spirit form to keep the link by brute force—but after realizing that the giant vine was very likely “alive”, and that there might even be a consciousness behind it, he no longer knew if he should.

Just then, the Goathead on the chart table finally seemed to notice something strange about him as well.

Its gaze fell on the flickering flames around him. After a brief delay, it muttered in a muffled voice: “Ah… you scared her…”

Duncan froze for a moment, then snapped his head up: “Scared who?”

“Atlantis…” Goathead seemed ready to sink back into its dreamy state. Its voice grew slower and slower. “Atlantis doesn’t know you. Your existence… scared her.”

Atlantis… the “World Tree” from the ancient legends of the elves?!

The information and a flood of guesses flashed through Duncan’s mind. But before he could ask more, a dizzy feeling struck him, like his senses were being peeled away and the whole world was rushing off into the distance. The scene before his eyes dimmed fast. The captain’s cabin, the chart table, the enchanted sea chart all faded into the dark. Only Goathead’s hazy, self-muttering voice echoed faintly in the darkness:

“Ah, time’s up—she’s waking up.”

In the next second, the feeling of solid ground under his feet snapped Duncan awake. He drew a reflexive breath and opened his eyes.

Alice’s face was only ten centimeters from his.

The silly doll startled him so badly that he jumped back. Alice at once broke into a beaming smile. She bounced after him and shouted: “Captain! Captain! It’s almost dawn! Everything outside looks normal again!”

Duncan had been about to scold Alice a few times, but her words stopped him short. Then he noticed how the world around them had changed.

The dense forest that had filled the whole block was gone. The huge growth that had merged into the tall buildings around them had vanished without a trace. The street fixtures that had twisted and mutated into part of the forest had really returned to their original forms.

On both sides of the road, the soft light from the gas lamps lit up the surroundings. Over the block, sunlight from the far-off sea coast spread across the city like a curtain. In the gaps in that light, the outline of the World’s Wound in the sky had already turned dim. At the far end of the sky,

a hint of dawn, just before Vision 001 rose, seemed to spread through the clouds.

Duncan blinked and looked, by habit, toward the sloping street deeper inside the district.

He still remembered the huge vine that had spread down from that slope, and how his flame had sunk into the depths of that vine.

There was nothing there now.

Just like the rest of the block—everything had gone back to normal.

With the rising morning sun, with the end of the veil of night and the coming of day, that massive, eerie phenomenon… dissolved into the light of morning like a dream being shaken away.

Duncan felt as if he stood at the edge of a bizarre dream. The displaced Mortal Realm and the memories still left in his head made everything before his eyes feel unreal.

But the dazed feeling only lasted a moment. He soon came fully back to himself and at once turned to look toward Crown Street.

His senses spread in that direction. The familiar Marks appeared in his “sight”.

Nina, Shirley, Morris…

Their presences had returned to the Mortal Realm.

The puppet head in Alice’s arms suddenly twitched. The mouth of the maid puppet opened and closed, and Lucretia’s voice came out: “Dad, we seem to…”

“I know. You’ve all come back, and the district is already back to normal.”

Duncan cut in quickly. Out of the corner of his eye, he could already see a few scattered figures on the street—that was the local residents coming out now that it was day.

They swept the streets. They chatted at their doors. They hurried off to work. They talked about yesterday's news and today's weather.

No one seemed to know what had happened last night—even though only a few hours ago, every one of these people in the district had truly vanished into the veil of night.

Now, they had come back too.

As the street scene slowly woke up and grew busy again, a faint, hard-to-name sense of strangeness and eeriness seemed to rise over it.

Chapter 575: Each Different

Duncan and Alice hurried back at top speed to the Witch manor at 99 Crown Street.

Along the way, what they saw were city streets that had fully returned to their everyday look. The blocks that had once been completely covered by “forest”, the nearby lanes once overrun by spreading vines, and the buildings that had fallen silent and empty in the forest’s Shadows had all regained their old, lively face in the early morning light.

There were more and more people on the streets. The first bus of the morning had already driven down the avenue. At the intersection, a Knowledge Guard was handing over the shift to a city Constable. The strange state that had filled the whole district a few hours ago… now felt like a grand illusion that only Duncan and the others had noticed.

When Duncan and Alice returned, everyone was already waiting in the living room. Lucretia was the first to come up. She walked quickly to Duncan and asked: “Are you all right?”

Duncan waved his hand as he headed into the living room and said quickly: “What I went through was different from you. We need to put all the information together now.”

Alice followed him in. As she passed Lucretia, she casually handed over the puppet head she had been carrying the whole way: “Here, this. I didn’t break it!”

Lucretia took the puppet head with a slightly odd look on her face. She glanced at the maid puppet leaning in standby against the stair rail not far away, then raised a hand to call over an iron footman. She passed the puppet head to it and said: “Put this in the workshop first. I’ll deal with it later.”

Soon, everyone gathered together. Duncan sat on the sofa in the middle of the living room and let his gaze sweep over each familiar face.

Even though he had known earlier that everyone was safe, he still could not help letting out a silent sigh of relief now that he saw them all back in the Mortal Realm.

“Let’s start with what we know so far.” After a brief silence, Duncan was the first to speak. “First, we can now say that the large-scale Visions in the city last night were very similar to the dream Taran Ael fell into before. The details were different, and there were many new changes, but they should all come from the influence of the so-called ‘dream of the Nameless One’. That ‘dream’ is growing, and now it seems to be in a runaway state and spreading toward the Mortal Realm.”

He paused for a moment and glanced at Alice beside him, then went on: “Second, after the anomaly began, all of us had different experiences. Alice and I stayed in the Mortal Realm. We saw streets warped and twisted by the power spilling out of the dream. I even made contact with a large entity that had ‘crawled out’ of the dream. You were dragged into the ‘other side’ of the dream. In that time, all contact was cut off, and only Lucretia kept a weak link with the Mortal Realm through the puppet servant she had made.”

“Let’s start with Lucretia, then. Each of you go over what you went through on the ‘inside’ of the dream.”

Duncan’s gaze fell on the Sea Witch. She nodded at once and shifted her sitting position a little: “Then I’ll start with mine. The place where I began my Dreamwalking was an uninhabited zone in the forest. There, I met an elven woman who called herself ‘Celine’…”

Nina, sitting to the side, let out a soft cry as soon as she heard this: “Huh? You met a person? Was she the Dreamer?”

Then she realized she had interrupted. She stuck out her tongue in embarrassment and said: “Sorry, I couldn’t help it… go on, I won’t cut in again.”

Lucretia did not mind. She only nodded to Nina and kept talking: “From what I could tell, the elven woman who called herself ‘Celine’ was not the Dreamer, but a… ‘resident’ of that huge dream. I know that sounds strange…

“She talked about a place called the ‘Wall of Silence’. It seemed to be a defensive line. She called herself a ranger, and she mentioned a retreat order. She told me that everyone had already pulled back inside the Wall of Silence. Until the dream ended, I was traveling with that elf, heading toward the place she called the ‘Wall of Silence’, but we never reached it…”

Lucretia described her experience in the dreamscape in as much detail as she could. Except for Duncan, who already knew some of it, everyone else listened with serious and amazed looks—because Lucretia was the only one among them who had met a “native resident” of the dream world.

No one had expected that there would be homegrown mind-born beings like “Celine” inside the “dream of the Nameless One”!

And if what the elf named “Celine” said was true, then beyond the depths of that forest, behind the defensive line called the “Wall of Silence”, there

were even more mind-born beings living inside the “dream of the Nameless One”?!

When Lucretia finished, the living room fell quiet for a moment. Then Morris spoke up: “Nina and I were together.”

Duncan was a little surprised: “The two of you were together?”

“Yes. It looks like there is some randomness to how we fell into the dreamscape. Not everyone was separated,” Morris said with a nod. “We also landed in a kind of ‘no man’s land’. All we could see around us was endless, nameless vegetation. At one point, Nina flew up to look into the distance. We found that there were some dark areas in the forest that looked like they were under corruption…

“And from our tests, whenever Nina released her power, the whole dreamscape would have a very strong ‘reaction’…”

Morris laid out their time in the “dream of the Nameless One” in a clear order. This was information Duncan had not had before. He frowned slightly and listened carefully to every detail the old Mr. described, especially how the “dream of the Nameless One” reacted violently whenever Nina used the power of the original Sun.

It sounded… like a strong rejection.

That made Duncan think back to his own experience in that dark, fog-filled space. According to that “suspicious Goathead”, the space had pushed him away because Atlantis was afraid. Then what about the rejection Nina had felt?

Could it be that Nina’s “sunlight” also made the dream of the Nameless One feel threatened?

Lost in thought, Duncan raised his head, and his gaze fell on Shirley.

“I met a cultist. An Annihilator,” Shirley said at once. She looked very pleased with herself, with a hint of pride in her voice. “I dug a lot of information out of that guy! And I beat him up in the end and had Dog leave a mark on him… Oh, and I ran into the whole forest suddenly going weird. It almost scared me to death. I think that was the ‘corruption zone’ Lucretia mentioned? The ‘corruption area’ that Old Gentleman and Nina saw—was that my side?”

Duncan’s eyes widened a little.

Everyone’s experience in the dream of the Nameless One had been different, but Shirley’s side sounded especially explosive.

His expression grew serious at once. He leaned forward without thinking and stared into Shirley’s eyes: “Slow down. Don’t jump all over the place—what exactly happened?”

“Okay, okay, let me sort it out first…” Seeing how serious the captain looked, Shirley straightened up at once and started digging through her memories. But even after she tried her best to put her words in order, she still scratched her cheek and said: “Um… Dog, you explain it. I’m afraid I’ll mess it up.”

In the next second, every gaze in the room turned to Dog.

Dog shook his head and let out a helpless sigh. Under Duncan’s gaze, he began: “We first ran into a rapid decay of the forest—which, based on the information we got later, should have been the ‘corruption’ phenomenon…”

Dog calmly laid out what he and Shirley had gone through in that forest. He described the way the forest had suddenly started to rot and twist, then the cultist they had met afterward, and the many bits of information Shirley had coaxed out of that cultist.

Duncan’s thoughts spread out as Dog spoke, matching each new piece of detail with the clues he already had and linking them together.

The corruption phenomenon. The defensive line called the “Wall of Silence”. The elf named Celine. The Annihilator. And… the sudden end of that uncanny dream.

“It seems… the corruption that elf named ‘Celine’ talked about was the same horrible phenomenon Shirley and Dog ran into,” Lucretia said thoughtfully. “The forest twisting into unnamable shapes, the ground turning corrosive and alive, everything becoming hostile… and those Annihilators seem to know even more.”

“It’s a pity that cultist still got away in the end,” Morris said, frowning. He shook his head. “If he is hiding in some other city in the Mortal Realm now, finding him again will not be easy.”

“More important is how those cultists are getting in and out of the dream of the Nameless One in the first place,” Vanna, who had been silent until now, suddenly said, breaking the quiet. “They seem to have some special method that lets them enter and leave that ‘dream’ under control, and even carry out organized operations inside it. That ‘method’ is key.”

Duncan nodded slowly at that. Then his gaze moved to Vanna.

“What did you see ‘over there’? Were you in the forest too?” he asked, curious.

Vanna looked around at the others. After a brief pause to think, she said: “That’s exactly what I wanted to talk about. What I went through was nothing like yours. Very, very different. When I hear you describe that forest, I feel really confused, because… I was in a desert.”

The living room fell silent at once.

Everyone stared at one another.

After several seconds, Duncan finally spoke in disbelief: “You were in a desert?! You didn’t see a forest at all?”

“Yes. No forest. Only sand, a few sparse, withered plants, and huge rocks,” Vanna said with a firm nod. “I climbed to the highest rocky hill and looked into the distance. There was no forest anywhere in sight.”

Chapter 576: Acting Separately

Vanna’s words left everyone present stunned.

They even shattered many of the guesses Duncan had just formed about the Dream of the Nameless One.

Vanna had not entered that “forest” at all—she had not even seen any forest. She had been trapped the whole time in a desert… What was that desert?!

After a brief, shocked silence, Duncan suddenly spoke: “Did you see any signs of humans moving about in the desert? Any strange terrain worth noting, or anything that left a deep impression on you?”

“There were many strange-looking boulders, tall and twisted, as if something moving had suddenly frozen and turned into stone. In the far distance I could see stretches of shadows, but I couldn’t tell if they were rocky ground or clusters of buildings—it was too far,” Vanna recalled her experience on the other side of the dream and described what she had seen: “Also, the most striking thing was a faint red rift in the sky. It was extremely, extremely large.”

“A red rift?” Duncan’s eyes changed at once and he straightened, suddenly alert: “What exactly did it look like? Besides that red rift, what else did you see in the sky?”

“I still remember how it looked…” Vanna said as she got up, took pen and paper from the low table, and quickly began to sketch: “Its color was dark red. Its edges were blurry, as if they were wrapped in clouds and mist. Deep inside it glowed faintly, and there were vague shapes within…”

Everyone’s gaze focused on the tip of Vanna’s pen. Duncan also leaned forward, watching the “crack” she drew on the paper with those messy lines. As the lines slowly matched the red glow in his memory, his expression grew more and more grim.

A moment later, Vanna stopped and pushed the paper forward: “This is more or less it. My drawing skills are limited, but I did my best. Other than this rift, I didn’t see anything else in the sky.”

“Nothing else?” Duncan was startled when he heard this. He asked without thinking: “What about the Sun? What did the Sun look like?”

To him, this was a question he had to ask—if Vanna had seen the Sun in that desert, then the form of that Sun would be crucial.

However, Vanna still shook her head: “There was no Sun—though it looked like daytime there, and the sky was filled with light besides the red glow, I didn’t see the Sun.”

Everyone looked at one another. Even Duncan was dazed for a moment, until Vanna’s voice sounded again and pulled them back: “That’s all the information I have.”

At last, everyone’s gaze settled on Duncan.

Nina blinked curiously: “Uncle Duncan, what did you see over there?”

“…Alice and I saw a distorted, mutated district in the Mortal Realm,” Duncan thought for a moment, then spoke slowly: “Tall trees and countless vines covered the streets, as if the forest from the Dream of the Nameless One had spread into the Mortal Realm. But we didn’t see any scenes related to a desert. And at the deepest part of that mutated district, we found an especially huge vine…”

With one more person came another line of thought, so Duncan did not hide what he had seen when he tried to probe that vine—the eerie Vanished

sailing through dark mist, the familiar yet strange Goathead on the Vanished, the enchanted sea chart that had changed, and the many pieces of information Goathead had revealed in something like a sleep-talking state.

When he finished speaking, the room became even quieter than after Vanna had finished.

“What you saw… was even more unbelievable than that desert I saw…” Vanna muttered.

Dog, beside her, also mumbled in a low voice: “Well… that is the captain, after all…”

Duncan glanced at the Abyssal Hound and ignored its comment. Instead, he added: “That ‘Goathead’ mentioned Atlantis at the end. That really caught my attention.”

“If I remember right… that’s the name of the ‘World Tree’ from ancient elven legends,” Vanna said with a slight nod. “It was also called the tree of life and the primordial giant tree. It was the first life created in this world by the Great Demon God Saslokar, whom the elves worship…”

Everyone present fell into their own thoughts. Even Alice, who usually could not keep up, now wore a look of serious thinking. After a short silence, Lucretia finally raised her head. She looked at Duncan with a hint of hesitation: “Dad, about the current ‘First Mate’ of the Vanished… you never really told me where it came from. That Goathead is actually…”

“It came from Subspace. That’s all I can tell you,” Duncan said. Then he shifted the topic: “But this time… I may have to go find it and confirm a few things.”

Now all the clues were finally laid out on the table. Everyone who had been scattered last night across the Mortal Realm and the different parts of the

dream had gathered all the information they held and placed it before Duncan.

After sorting his thoughts, Duncan let out a quiet breath, set aside the tangled questions in his mind for now, and let his gaze sweep over everyone in the living room.

“Now, we can be sure of a few things—

“First, the Dream of the Nameless One is growing larger. Its influence is getting stronger, and it has already reached the point where it can interfere with the Mortal Realm. For now we can’t tell what caused this change, but it is most likely linked to the coming so-called fourth Long Night and the changes of the Sun.

“Second, the ordinary people in the city-state seem completely unaware of the Dream of the Nameless One. When the anomaly happens, everyone within the dream’s affected area disappears. When the dream ends, they return to the Mortal Realm and go on with their daily lives. We still don’t know where they go while the dream is happening, and we don’t know if this phenomenon is limited to elves. There are also many merchants and adventurers of other races in Lightwind Harbor. Next we have to find a way to confirm what happened to those people last night.

“Third, when the anomaly happens, we are scattered to different places—some stay in the Mortal Realm, some enter the great forest in the Dreamwalking state, and some end up in that mysterious desert. We still don’t know if this ‘scattering’ is random or follows some rule.

“Fourth, the Annihilators and the Suntists, and the Ender who feeds them information behind the scenes—these cultists clearly know much more…”

He summed up all the known information point by point, then finally looked up at the others: “Is there anything to add?”

“I can’t think of anything else for now,” Lucretia said with a shake of her head. “What I care about now is whether that kind of anomaly from last night will happen again, and how we should respond if it does.”

“Most likely it will,” Morris sighed. “The influence of the Dream of the Nameless One is clearly still growing stronger. The anomalies it causes will only increase. But looking at the bright side—the more it appears, the more chances we have to figure out its patterns. Right now we have many guesses we can’t confirm, but many of those questions can be answered as soon as there’s a second large-scale anomaly.”

Listening to the old scholar’s analysis, Duncan nodded in agreement: “That’s not blind optimism. We really do need more anomalies to work out the rules of the Dream of the Nameless One.”

“But the Dream of the Nameless One will scatter us and cut off our connection to the captain,” Vanna added from the side. “That’s a big problem.”

“I already have a rough idea about that,” Duncan said thoughtfully, recalling last night—especially the vague information he had sensed after linking with that huge vine and stepping onto that eerie version of the Vanished. “If the Dream of the Nameless One expands again, I should have a chance to test this idea.”

Shirley lifted her head and looked at Duncan, then at the others: “Then… what about this period? What are we going to do next?”

“We don’t know when the Dream of the Nameless One will change again,” Duncan said, turning his gaze to Lucretia. “Right now we have to find out whether other parts of the city-state were also affected last night. The fastest way is to contact the Governor of Lightwind Harbor.”

“Leave that to me,” Lucretia said at once. “I’ll go find Sara Mell in a bit and see if he noticed what happened last night.”

Duncan made a sound of agreement, then looked at Morris and Vanna: “We also need to investigate the nearby districts. We have to see whether, besides the elves, the other nonhuman folk living around Crown Street were affected by the dream, and whether they had any unusual experiences last night.”

“Understood,” Vanna nodded right away. “This is something I’m good at.”

Morris also nodded: “I know some old friends at Truth Academy. When we investigate, I can ask them to help make things easier.”

Duncan’s gaze finally turned to Nina and Shirley.

“You two stay home for now,” Duncan said after a short pause. “We don’t need you to do anything yet. But if we find any clues about Suntists or Annihilators, we might need your help.”

Nina looked a little disappointed, but still answered obediently: “Oh…”

Shirley, beside her, asked curiously: “What about you?”

“I’m going back to the ship,” Duncan said as he rose from the sofa. “I’ll leave now.”

Alice stood up without thinking: “Then I’ll go too!”

Duncan stopped and gave the doll a puzzled look: “Why are you coming along?”

Alice thought for a moment, glanced at the others in the living room, then scratched her hair and said, perfectly justified: “I don’t know either!”

Duncan was speechless.

After a brief silence, he suddenly laughed and sighed.

“Fine. If you want to come, then come along. I don’t feel at ease leaving you in the city anyway.”

Alice brightened at once: “Hehe…”

A short while later, everyone set out according to the plan.

Chapter 577: Goathead’s Memory

Out at sea off Lightwind Harbor, near the edge of the area lit by the glowing geometric body, fog gathered over the water. A huge ghost ship hid within the mist and slowly patrolled the ocean.

A streak of ghost-green flame flashed through the thick fog.

A doorway of fire burst open on the deck of the Vanished, and Duncan and Alice stepped out through it.

The familiar deck, the familiar masts, the familiar spirit form sails. Even though he had been away only a short time, Duncan still felt a wave of relief when he returned to the Vanished. As he looked at these familiar sights on the ship and felt the salty sea breeze over the deck, he slowly let out a breath and felt his mood calm down bit by bit.

At the same time, he instinctively remembered the “vision” he had seen last night while probing that huge vine. He remembered that eerie Vanished sailing through dark, thick mist—

The scene in his memory overlapped naturally with what was before his eyes now, as if there was no difference between them.

“…They really were exactly the same…” he muttered under his breath.

“Huh?” Alice’s voice sounded from beside him at once: “What’s exactly the same?”

Duncan shook his head and glanced at the silly doll who had followed him even though she did not know what she was going to do. A smile appeared

on his face.

“I’m going to the captain’s cabin to talk with the First Mate. You go do your own things first.”

“Oh, okay!” Alice nodded at once: “Then I’ll go to the kitchen and take care of the fish and dried meat we salted earlier. Shirley and Nina said they wanted to eat them~~”

As she spoke, the doll waved to Duncan and walked happily toward the kitchen. It was clear that as soon as she returned to the Vanished, her mood improved right away.

Then again, she usually seemed cheerful anyway. She was happy on the ship and happy in the city as well—inside Alice’s head, it seemed there were only two moods: “happy” and “even happier.”

Watching the doll’s light steps as she left, Duncan’s lips also curled up a little. Then he shook his head, straightened his expression, and turned to walk toward the aft deck.

The door of the captain’s cabin appeared before him. Duncan stopped in front of it and looked up at the doorframe.

The words “Door of the Lost Ones” came into view. The carved letters looked old and powerful, their grooves sunken as if they carried the weight of countless ages.

Duncan quietly cast his gaze over the words on the doorframe. The only difference between the eerie Vanished that sailed in dark mist and the ship now under his feet seemed to be this line of words on the captain’s cabin door.

Of course, there might be other differences between the two ships, and those differences might hold more clues. But their last contact had been too

rushed for him to find them. For now, the only thing he was sure of was that the Door of the Lost Ones showed different details on the two ships.

The Door of the Lost Ones was extremely special—even on the Vanished, which was full of anomalies and strange powers, this door was still extraordinary.

It was the only "path" Duncan had to return to his small apartment. It was also a checkpoint this ship used to verify the captain's authority. The words on its doorframe did not belong to any known language, but anyone who looked at them could still read their meaning, even someone like Alice, who had been illiterate at first, or a native from some remote city-state who only knew obscure local characters.

On different "versions" of the Vanished, this door also showed different states. In the Mortal Realm, it led to that apartment. In Subspace, behind it lay a strange dark space. In the mist, the words on the door changed to "May He Wander in the Dream"—and a familiar yet strange Goathead slept within that door.

…Just what was this so-called Door of the Lost Ones?

With that question and many thoughts in his heart, Duncan reached out and opened the captain's cabin door.

In the swaying lamplight, the familiar chart table and shelves came into view. Goathead, perched on the edge of the table, creaked and turned its head this way. When it saw Duncan, its obsidian-carved eyes seemed to light up, and its cheerful, noisy voice rang in Duncan's ears: "Oh! The great captain has returned to his loyal Vanished! Your loyal—well, you know the rest—salutes you! I didn't expect you back so soon. Was life in the city pleasant? Were you worried about the ship, or did you come back because…"

“I have something I want to talk to you about.” Duncan walked to the chart table and spoke in a very serious tone.

The captain’s solemn words instantly cut off Goathead’s chatter. The eerie black wooden idol gave a creak and straightened its neck like someone snapping to attention, as if trying hard to look serious. Its voice could not help but carry a hint of tension: “Captain, what happened? Did something happen in Lightwind Harbor too?”

Duncan sat down at the chart table. His eyes first fell on the enchanted sea chart on the table, on the familiar fog and the route. Then he heard Goathead’s words and frowned: “Why did you say ‘too’?”

“Because Pland and Frostholm both had incidents before…”

Duncan stared into Goathead’s eyes: “The way you put it makes me sound like a walking calamity.”

Goathead seemed a little stunned: “…Aren’t you?”

“I’ve been working hard to improve the Vanished’s official image on the Boundless Sea, and I’ve had great success in Pland and Frostholm. The leaders of both city-states are very friendly to me now, and I haven’t received any complaints from any city-state so far. As my First Mate, I hope you can look at our work with a more forward-looking eye,” Duncan said, waving his hand. “Of course, that’s not what I came to talk about today. I want to know what you were doing last night.”

“Last night?” Goathead paused, not understanding why the topic suddenly shifted this way, but still answered quickly: “Last night I was watching over the ship, just as you ordered. We stayed in waters far from the official route and kept ourselves hidden in the fog, so we wouldn’t scare those easily spooked fellows…”

Duncan was not surprised by this answer.

From the conversation he had last night with that “eerie Goathead,” it was clear the other one did not know him. The two Goatheads were obviously not the same.

But there had to be some other connection between them.

After thinking for a moment, he broke the silence again: “I want to learn more about you—your origin, your past, and your… nature.”

His tone was extremely serious. His expression was unusually solemn, and his slightly leaning body seemed to give off a silent pressure.

He chose to address this with his First Mate in the most direct way, rather than hiding his intentions or probing with roundabout questions.

He did not need those methods—at least not on this ship. He already knew the rules by which the Vanished operated, and he had worked out his own “code of conduct” here. He already understood that as long as he did not take that overly dangerous step, both Goathead and the Vanished itself would remain in a kind of “stable” state. It was something like… a form of containment.

Visions could not be “contained” the way anomalies could. But in this world there were always anomalies and manifestations that went beyond the usual rules. Vision 005 – the Vanished was actually already in a kind of contained state now—Duncan himself was the containment condition for this ship.

Goathead seemed frightened.

It was used to the captain’s usual mild and friendly manner. It knew that although the captain had a very terrifying side, he was always reliable and kind when dealing with his own people on the ship. The way Duncan was acting now, and the questions he was asking, filled it with a kind of… unease.

“…Why are you asking this all of a sudden?” it asked without thinking.

“I never asked before because there was no need,” Duncan said slowly. “But now some things have happened. In Lightwind Harbor, a strange phenomenon appeared that is connected to you. So I have to ask you about it.”

Goathead’s neck swayed slightly from side to side, as if it were trying to ease its nervousness.

Duncan kept staring into its eyes and slowly pressed his hand onto the chart table.

Threads of ghostly green flame spread from his palm, seeping into the floor and walls of the captain’s cabin, and into every seam of the ship. A low creaking sound came from deep within the hull, and it seemed as if the very “mood” of the ship was quietly changing.

“I am Duncan Abnomar, the captain of this ship,” Duncan said. His voice was deep, as if he had gone back to the day he first took the helm, declaring his identity to the whole ship. “I command this ship and make it sail on the Boundless Sea. As the captain, I am asking my First Mate some questions. This is only a conversation—because of it, this ship will not sink back into Subspace, and nothing else will change. Because—I am Duncan Abnomar, the captain of this ship.”

Blazing ghostly green flames rose from every part of Duncan’s body. In the fire, his figure turned into a terrifying, hazy spirit form. His voice seemed to echo through the whole ship—

“My First Mate, where exactly did you come from?”

Goathead lifted its head and calmly met Duncan’s gaze: “I came from Subspace.”

“Details,” Duncan said. “Subspace is too vague a concept. You know that’s not what I’m really asking.”

“Subspace is a vague concept, and also the only concept. There are no ‘places’ in Subspace, Captain, and the beings in Subspace have no past or future,” Goathead replied. It suddenly seemed to lose all hesitation, and there was no more doubt or fear in its words. “I don’t know my origin. I don’t know what happened in the past. You want to know my ‘nature’—but even I don’t know my ‘nature’. I… don’t remember.”

“Then what do you still remember?”

Goathead suddenly fell silent. Under Duncan’s gaze, it became as still as a real wooden carving. After who knew how long, it suddenly moved again, and a hoarse, deep voice came from its throat: “‘Remember them.’”

“Remember them?” Duncan was startled, and his brows drew together: “What does that mean?”

Goathead shook its head slightly: “I don’t know, but this is the only sentence I remember. I have to remember them. I must remember them. But… I don’t know who they are. I really… don’t remember.”

Chapter 578: Agatha’s Information

Duncan knew Goathead had no reason to lie to him. Or rather, even if it wanted to, it would not use such clumsy acting.

That one stray sentence was the only memory the First Mate had brought back from Subspace. It really seemed not to know what had happened, or what came before and after that line.

Duncan braced both hands on the table and sat back down in the chair behind the chart table. He looked closely into Goathead’s eyes, as if he wanted to dig more secrets out of those obsidian-carved pupils: “So, a very long time ago, there were people who were very important to you. You tried desperately to remember them. Back then, you already knew you would one day forget many things, so ‘remember them’ became a strong thought in your mind… It was so strong, yet it still could not stop what happened. Now, all you remember is this one sentence.”

“Maybe… that was it,” Goathead said, a bit unsure. “But I do not feel regret. I just feel confused sometimes…”

It muttered as it spoke, then suddenly stopped and looked up at Duncan: “Captain, what exactly happened? What kind of thing could still be related to me?”

Duncan sat in the chair, lost in thought. He curled his fingers and tapped lightly on the table. The flame of his spirit form turned into ripples like water and spread out with each tap.

“…The Nameless One’s dream grew in influence and last night spread into the Mortal Realm. I touched one of the ‘roots’ that extended from that dream into the Mortal Realm. If my guess is right… what I reached was one of the world’s foundations in the original faith of the Elves, Atlantis.”

A sharp crack came from beneath Goathead’s neck. Its whole head froze on the pedestal.

Duncan glanced at it and said calmly: “You snapped too early.”

“Ah… huh?”

“After I touched Atlantis, I entered a dimension that was neither dream nor the Mortal Realm. Another Vanished was sailing in that dimension. And on that Vanished… there was another you.”

Goathead’s neck gave another loud crack at once.

Duncan ignored the eerie noises coming from his eerie First Mate. He calmly told Goathead about his experience last night, especially the changes in the Gate of the Lost Ones on that strange ghost ship, and the odd reactions of that other Goathead who felt both familiar and strange.

As he spoke, he kept watching the Goathead in front of him, studying its expression and movements.

Its reaction did not seem suspicious. It was shock, and nothing but shock. Even with that stiff wooden face, the stunned look was clear at a glance.

“You look very surprised,” Duncan finally finished telling the whole story and nodded to the First Mate on the table. “Now you know why I am taking this so seriously.”

“I… yes, now I fully understand your reaction,” Goathead said hesitantly. “But I do not know… I do not remember…”

“I should have mentioned this to you. In Subspace, I also saw a Vanished. That ship was badly damaged, like a shadow of the Vanished after even longer ages of decay and rot. But the only strange thing about that ship was the ship itself. You were not on it,” Duncan said slowly. “And now I have seen a third Vanished. It sails in darkness and fog, and there is another you on board. What about the future? Will there be a fourth ship, a fifth? In the end, what state is this ship in right now? Do you have no clue at all?”

Goathead hesitated. This time it stayed silent for a long while, as if it was trying to find a “safe” way to face this topic. After who knew how long, it finally spoke: “I do not know if you will run into a fourth or fifth Vanished. I do not know into how many strange ‘states’ this ship can split or appear. But there is one thing that may help your thinking… this ship has not always looked like this.”

“Not always like this?” Duncan frowned. “I guess… you are not talking about the change that happened when the Vanished fell into Subspace?”

“No. The change was much greater than that, much more complete,” Goathead slowly shook its head. “In my broken and messy memories, it once took many forms: huge blocks of iron, swelling and writhing flesh, dark and icy rock, abstract and terrifying Shadows. In the deepest part of Subspace, it could look different at any moment. This state lasted for…”

Goathead suddenly stopped.

Duncan heard a low creak and a disturbing, muffled echo coming from deep in the ship. The floor under his feet trembled slightly. A tense, uneasy feeling slowly spread through the whole ship, as if the entire vessel was shivering and losing its stability.

“Let us stop here. I can picture the state you are describing,” Duncan said softly.

Goathead nodded carefully.

The tension and trembling that filled the ship slowly faded. In the Mortal Realm, the ship returned to a stable state again.

Duncan kept his brows knitted, deep in thought.

Just now, the ship had almost collapsed into some other form because of Goathead's description. But under his own gaze as captain, it finally returned to a stable containment state.

So, had the brief change in the Vanished just now been showing him some kind of "essence" of the ship? Or… something even more?

After thinking in silence for a while, Duncan shook his head and let his gaze fall back on Goathead: "What do you think about the 'other you' on that ship?"

"I am sorry, Captain. I do not know."

Goathead muttered in frustration. In this short time, these seemed to be the words it said the most, along with "I do not remember."

Duncan was not surprised by this answer. He went on and asked another question: "Do you dream?"

"Dream?" Goathead was stunned for a moment, then quickly shook its head. This time it answered very smoothly: "I do not dream. Your loyal First Mate is always awake. After all, this ship still depends on me to keep an eye on everything at all times…"

Duncan ignored the boasting in the second half. After hearing Goathead's answer, he only murmured thoughtfully: "You do not dream…"

Goathead spoke again, a bit uneasy: "Captain…"

Duncan looked at it: "Speak."

Goathead looked a bit awkward and hesitated for a long time before speaking: “You just mentioned that on that eerie Vanished, the door to the captain’s cabin had the words ‘May He wander in the dream’ written on it. And the ‘me’ in that captain’s cabin also mentioned the name Atlantis to you. Are you suspecting…”

“Yes.” Duncan nodded calmly before it could finish.

Goathead suddenly did not know how to continue.

“But all I can do is suspect,” Duncan went on. “Unless one day you suddenly recover your memory and tell me with your own mouth that you have a name… and that name is ‘Saslokar’.”

Silence fell over the captain’s cabin.

After who knew how long, Goathead finally broke the silence, muttering: “Most of the Elves’ ancient tales are bizarre and full of contradictions. You cannot really take them as truth…”

“But the more bizarre and self-contradictory an ancient tale is, the more it is worth digging into once it suddenly links up with clues in the Mortal Realm,” Duncan said, calm and serious. “In the end, you do not know your own past either, do you?”

“Even so, this is still too strange,” Goathead grumbled. “I do not want to be tied to an ancient story of that level. And honestly, look at me now. I am just a piece of sculpture on the ship…”

Duncan neither agreed nor argued. He only shook his head and sighed, then rose from beside the chart table and walked slowly to the window. He looked out at the rail bathed in sunlight and mist, and at the rolling sea in the distance.

A light, glass-tapping sound suddenly reached his ears.

Duncan immediately looked toward the sound.

Agatha's ghostly figure quietly appeared on the windowpane and raised a hand to point in a certain direction.

Duncan frowned slightly, then turned back to glance at Goathead, who was still muttering by the edge of the chart table.

After a brief pause, he walked over and said: "Do not think too much about it for now. No matter what, your first duty now is to be the Vanished's First Mate. Help me watch over this ship. Leave the other matters to me."

Goathead gave a little jolt, as if it suddenly woke up. It looked at its captain, who was lowering his head to look at it, seemed stunned for a moment, then hurriedly answered: "Ah, ah, yes, Captain, I… I understand."

"Good," Duncan nodded slightly, then walked toward the door in the back of the captain's cabin. "I will go back to my room to rest for a while and sort out my thoughts."

Goathead's voice came from behind him at once: "Yes, Captain!"

Duncan did not look back. He waved a hand and walked into his own captain's quarters. After closing the door behind him, he did not really go to rest. Instead he went to the mirror in the corner of the room.

After listening for a moment to make sure it was quiet outside, Duncan stepped forward and tapped on the mirror with a curled finger.

Shadows and smoke rose within the glass. Agatha's figure appeared in the mirror. The former Gatekeeper, who now lived in the Vanished's mirrors, nodded to Duncan in greeting.

"You have something to tell me, and you chose to say it here. Is it to avoid the First Mate?" Duncan's face was serious. "What is going on?"

“I heard your talk with the First Mate, Captain. I have a situation to report,” Agatha nodded and said solemnly. “Last night, nothing was normal on the Vanished. Its ‘shadow’ disappeared for a time.”

Chapter 579: The Spreading Influence

When Duncan heard Agatha's report, his first reaction was to glance at the bedroom door from the corner of his eye.

Then he drew back his gaze and looked at the former Gatekeeper in the mirror, his expression unusually serious: "You mean its reflection on the sea?"

"Not just its reflection on the sea, but also its projection in the Spirit Realm. Under normal conditions these two 'shadows' are deeply linked and affect each other," Agatha said seriously. "Late last night, I was moving through the mirrors on the ship as usual, checking the whole vessel, when I suddenly found this problem. At the time I thought it was just some 'special feature' of the Vanished itself. After all, I know very little about it…"

"The Vanished does not have that kind of feature. At least as far as I know, its 'shadow' would not suddenly vanish for no reason," Duncan shook his head. "When did this happen? How long did it roughly last?"

Agatha nodded at once: "Judging by the time, it happened during the period you mentioned, when the Nameless One's dream was spreading. It lasted until the first gleam of dawn appeared on the sea horizon."

Duncan did not speak. He only frowned hard, and a look of deep thought came over his face.

After a brief silence, Agatha went on: “When the Vanished’s shadow disappeared, I happened to be moving through mirrors in the Mortal Realm. Normally, I can use those mirrors to ‘jump’ straight into the Spirit Realm, or step into the Vanished’s reflection on the sea. But last night, those ‘jumping paths’ vanished along with the Vanished’s shadow…”

“But from what I felt… the realm on the ‘other side’ of the mirrors did not truly stop existing. Instead there was some barrier I could not understand, blocking me. It kept me from seeing the path in the mirror or sensing what lay beyond…”

Listening to Agatha’s account, Duncan seemed to think of something: “You mean… you believe the Vanished’s ‘shadow’ did not really vanish, but shifted into a state you could not understand or observe at the time. Or in other words, there was a wall of ‘perception’ that kept you locked on the Mortal Realm side?”

“That is a good way to put it,” Agatha said, looking a bit relieved. “I thought my description would be too abstract, and that it would take a lot of effort to explain it to you…”

“In Pland and Frostholm, I have dealt with all sorts of ‘Veils’,” Duncan said casually. Then he thought for a moment and glanced toward the door. “So, after hearing my talk with Goathead, you became suspicious, because my First Mate did not mention last night’s anomaly at all.”

“I do not know why this happened. In theory… it should be able to sense changes in the Spirit Realm. Its senses in that area might not be as sharp as mine, but it should not be completely unaware,” Agatha said, her tone slightly hesitant. “Especially with what you just mentioned: the existence of another ‘Goathead’, and that one’s strange and suspicious behavior…”

Duncan let out a slow breath and said: “You think Goathead is no longer reliable, because it may be hiding something from me.”

“…I know that as a new crew member, I should not question the ship’s First Mate. That is a serious taboo. But as a former Gatekeeper, I have an instinctive… ‘alertness’ toward things like this,” Agatha chose her words with care and spoke sincerely. “Many irreversible disasters all start from a small feeling that something is ‘not quite right’.”

Duncan listened in silence, neither agreeing nor denying.

After a long time, he finally spoke, still thinking it through: “There may be two explanations. Either Goathead knows what happened but chose not to tell me and is hiding things on purpose, or even it does not know what changed on the Vanished last night.”

Agatha froze for a moment, then quickly reacted: “The second explanation would mean…”

“That some force is affecting this ship. Goathead is also within the range of that influence,” Duncan said sternly. “You were not affected, so you could see the changes that happened to the Vanished during the night.”

…

Humming a cheerful tune whose name she could not even remember, Alice bustled back and forth in the kitchen.

For her, the busy days on the Vanished were always the happiest.

Here she had everything she knew: the familiar deck, the familiar kitchen, the familiar pots and pans, and the familiar barrels, knives, and spatulas.

They were all her Friends. Everything on this ship was her Friend. And most of the time, she felt that dealing with the Friends on the ship was much easier than dealing with people in the city-states.

Going into the cities and dealing with people meant she had to learn too much, remember too much knowledge, and pay attention to a pile of dull

“rules” that made her sleepy. Those beings called Humans were always far too fragile. They let countless “threads” float off them with no protection, and if she casually grabbed one, they would break in strange, unfixable ways. They were even more precious and fragile than the ship’s porcelain and glassware.

But the captain cared a lot about those “people”. He did not want her to tug at the “threads” on others at will, and he especially did not want her to break people who were not supposed to be broken.

For Alice, that was a little hard.

It was as hard as putting a cat in a room full of yarn balls and then not letting it touch a single loose end.

So after the novelty of a few trips into the cities wore off, Alice found that she still liked living on the ship best. Because here, she could hardly beat anyone at all.

She just had to be careful not to “touch” the Friends who lived on the ship with her.

She liked it this way. She liked the world around her feeling solid and stable.

She lifted the lid of a barrel of salted fish and leaned in carefully to sniff the smell inside. A satisfied look appeared on Alice’s face.

The captain never quite understood this, and neither did the others on the ship. Why would a doll have a sense of smell?

Alice herself did not know, but she never thought too much about it.

She only felt satisfied with her craft. She picked up a wooden basin from the side, ready to take some salted fish out of the barrel. She reached her hand toward the barrel, but before she could grab anything, a long-handled

ladle on the counter suddenly jumped up and smacked her arm with a loud slap.

Alice cried out, quickly pulled her hand back, and protested: “I washed my hands! I just washed them!”

The long-handled ladle wobbled by the rim of the barrel and still refused to move aside.

Alice pouted, a bit unhappy: “You are no fun!”

The ladle slowly floated up. The bowl of the spoon made little gestures in front of the doll.

“…Fine,” Alice finally gave in with a sigh, muttering as she grabbed the handle. “It was just that last time my head fell into the barrel when I bent over to get something. Do you really have to make such a fuss over it…”

She scooped fish out of the barrel and chatted idly with the Friends in the kitchen. Sometimes she talked about what she had seen in the city-states. Sometimes she talked about things related to the captain.

Then she began to check the other containers that held stored food. Since AI could supply the Vanished with fresh ingredients at any time, most of the food stored here was processed things that could be kept for many years. Salted fish was the most popular among them.

There were twelve big barrels used to store salted fish.

Starting from the door, Alice counted along the wall: one, two, three, four… twelve, thirteen.

She suddenly stopped.

The doll girl blinked in confusion, went back to the start, and counted again.

There were still thirteen.

One more barrel had appeared.

Alice stood dazed in front of the row of barrels, her mind working hard. At first she suspected that she had messed up the numbers again. Her math had never been very good. Sometimes she was even worse than Shirley. But soon she felt she could not be that stupid. After all, it was only counting twelve barrels.

She already knew how to add and subtract numbers with more than two digits.

So Alice rubbed her eyes, calmed herself, and counted again.

Twelve.

The extra number from before was gone. Everything was back to normal.

Alice counted the barrels again and again. At last she was sure she had not miscounted anymore, yet her puzzlement did not ease at all. She turned her head and looked at the other things in the kitchen, then could not help asking curiously: “Did you notice? Just now it felt like there was one more barrel!”

But the Friends in the kitchen had no way to answer her for real. Even if they could speak, these things were at most Restless Objects that showed some traits of living beings only because of the Vanished’s special environment. They did not have full minds that could help solve a doll’s confusion.

Alice got no answer, so she turned back again and patted the big barrels lined up along the wall: “Was there one more among you just now?”

The barrels did not answer her either.

…

Sara Mell stared in shock as the “witch of the sea” spoke to her. She did not even notice the food slipping from her hand onto the table.

She no longer cared to complain that this freecoming witch had barged into her home early in the morning and interrupted her breakfast.

“All these unbelievable things… they all happened last night?”

The Elven governor spoke in disbelief. At first she wanted to say, “Are you making fun of me?” but when she thought about this witch’s temper, she decided not to make such a pointless provocation.

“Judging from your reaction, things are just as I expected,” Lucretia sighed. She sat on the chair opposite Sara Mell. The servants, who had been shaking in fear in the dining room, had already been driven out before she started talking “business”. Now only she and the governor were left. “The reach of that ‘dream’… was wider than we thought.”

Chapter 580: Touching the Edge

Sara Mell no longer cared about his breakfast.

This former legendary explorer, who had seen countless strange and eerie sights on the Boundless Sea, faced many layers of corruption and death, and built a city-state at the end of the storm, now rarely showed an uneasy expression. He sat in his chair with his brows tightly drawn together, while a long-lost shadow of unease spread through his heart.

He knew this feeling well. It was the warning his instincts gave when a huge, bizarre danger, beyond human understanding and resistance, slowly drew near.

He did not doubt Lucretia's account.

This was not his first time dealing with the "Sea Witch". Countless Deep-Sea Captains and frontier explorers saw this Witch as one of the Shadows on the Boundless Sea and were deeply wary of her strange temper and dangerous power. But Sara Mell knew very clearly that, in the end, the Sea Witch still stood on the side of Mortals.

The dining room stayed quiet for a long time before Sara Mell finally came out of his thoughts. He raised his head and said: "So far, no one has reported anything strange last night. Neither the local elven residents nor the nonhuman folk living here noticed the dream you mentioned."

"From what my Father saw, the anomaly in the district was very obvious and on a large scale. If some parts of the city had really stayed normal, then the residents of those 'normal' districts could not have failed to notice the

anomalies in the neighboring streets. So the only explanation is that last night… the whole of Lightwind Harbor was Dreamwalking."

Lucretia's last sentence sent an indescribable chill through Sara Mell, but his reason still pushed him to think about what did not fit in the logic. He asked: "You said the buildings in the Mortal Realm were covered or even parasitized by 'corruption entities' spreading from the dream, with huge plants piercing through walls and streets? None of that left any trace?"

"No trace was left. Before the Sun rose, the Mortal Realm had already returned to normal."

Sara Mell listened, frowning in silence, and seemed to fall into thought once more.

"What are you thinking of?" Lucretia asked curiously from the side.

"…Maybe I should send people to check all the gas meters and electricity meters across the city, and the night-time operation of the factories," Sara Mell said as he thought. "The city-state is not still at night. Many functions run day and night to keep it working, like the three pillars of gas, electricity, and steam. Each has its own night monitoring and patrol staff…

"So that raises a question: when that dream came, where did these people go? What state were the machines they should have been running in? And there are the night watch scholars at the colleges. Many of them need to record their work status at set times…"

Sara Mell paused to think, then went on: "We also have to find a way to figure out how far this anomaly spread. Was it limited to the main island of Lightwind Harbor, or did it reach the patrol fleet off the coast, or even the fallen relic over there…"

As this governor spoke, he stood up from behind the table and began to pace beside the dining table, stopping now and then to think with a grave

look.

He seemed to have completely forgotten that there was still a “Sea Witch” sitting here.

Lucretia did not find it strange. She knew that before this governor became City Lord, he had first been an outstanding adventurer (though still not as good as Father). And a good adventurer knew how to deal with all kinds of extraordinary manifestations.

Lightwind Harbor had managed to thrive so close to the border sea all these years, and this governor’s ability was beyond doubt.

She had finished what Father had told her to do. Lucretia stood up without disturbing the governor, who was deep in thought. Her gaze swept over the table; she casually picked up a bottle of unopened spiced wine, and then her figure burst apart into a swirl of colorful paper scraps that spun up through the roof and vanished from the room.

After a while, Sara Mell suddenly came back to himself. He turned around in a hurry and said: “Ah, I’m sorry, I drifted off for a moment, Lady Lucretia, would you like to stay and have some—”

He stared blankly at the empty chair opposite the table, and at the spot where his treasured wine had been. That place was empty too.

“…Again?!”

…

“The number of barrels changed?”

In the captain’s cabin, after hearing Alice rush in to report, Duncan could not help but ask again in surprise.

“Yes, yes!” Alice nodded again and again. “I counted several times! I definitely didn’t count wrong! And I’m sure I remember it right. I moved all

those barrels there myself.”

Alice would of course never lie. As for making a mistake with the number… she should not mess up something this simple either.

After a short pause, Duncan stood up from behind the chart table and said: “Take me to see it.”

“Okay!” Alice answered without any hesitation.

The Goathead at the edge of the chart table stirred. It turned its head toward Duncan, speaking with a hint of hesitation: “Captain, then I…”

“You keep steering,” Duncan said at once. He paused, then added: “Don’t worry about anything else. Like I said, leave it to me.”

“Yes, Captain.”

Led by Alice, Duncan soon reached the place where the salted fish were stored.

Of course, the place had already returned to normal. Twelve wooden barrels stood neatly in a row against the wall, no more and no less.

Duncan still kept a serious expression as his gaze swept the whole cabin.

Wherever he looked, faint strands of ghostly green flame flickered in the air like illusions and slipped quietly through the cracks in the floor and walls. The whole room seemed wrapped in a mist woven from spirit form fire, shifting back and forth between the Spirit Realm and the Mortal Realm.

He was checking whether any “traces” were left here, whether something that did not belong to the Vanished had entered this place.

Alice’s report did not sound like a big deal. On this ghost ship full of strange things, a single barrel not on the “list” hardly seemed worth such a fuss. But Duncan did not relax at all.

Because on the Boundless Sea, even the smallest oddity had to be treated with care—especially on the Vanished, and especially at a time like this.

Duncan had already sensed something was wrong from last night's events. His talk with Goathead today, and Agatha's report, made him feel more and more that something was off.

This ship seemed to be in a slightly strange state.

It had not slipped out of his control, but Duncan kept feeling that some "details" were appearing on this ship that he did not know or understand.

Either some hidden secrets of the Vanished were slowly lifting their veil to him, or some parts of the ship really were slowly slipping out of the captain's control.

As the spreading spirit form flames soaked through everything, Duncan felt his link with the Vanished grow stronger. Every detail of the ship began to appear in his mind—the deck, the masts, the sails, the complex winches and lines, the cabins below the deck, and the vague, shadowy parts that lay soaked in the Boundless Sea.

He had done this more than once, so the feeling was not new. After his senses quickly adjusted, he let his perception merge with the ship and continued to spread into the depths of the Vanished.

The cabin where the kitchen sat showed no anomalies. The nearby cabins and the deeper layers were also all normal.

Thin streams of light soaked into the depths of the Vanished, flowing through the ship like some kind of signal. They finally gathered in the captain's cabin, converging on a single bright "focus".

That was where Goathead sat, the control center of the ship at this moment.

Duncan's "gaze" lingered on that focus for a long time.

Everything there also looked normal.

Duncan slowly drew back his “gaze”—but he left a small flame in the deepest darkness.

At the same time, as he withdrew his gaze from the whole ship, he kept leaving Fire Seeds behind, letting them stay in different parts of the Vanished.

Alice watched the captain without blinking, a little worried. Only after a long time did she see Duncan’s eyes move. She hurried closer and asked: “Captain, Captain, how is it? Did you find anything?”

“There is no anomaly on the ship—don’t worry,” Duncan slowly showed a small smile and reached out to ruffle Alice’s hair. “It might just be some minor issue, like a bit of spatial misalignment or a trick of light and shadow. I’ll take care of it.”

Alice did not really understand, but she still nodded half in confusion: “Ah… oh.”

After briefly comforting the Doll, Duncan turned his gaze to a spot not far away.

On a pillar two meters away hung an oil lamp with a glass shade. Now shadows and mist slowly formed on the surface of that shade, and Agatha’s figure appeared in the glass.

“Keep an eye on the reflections in the Spirit Realm,” Duncan nodded to her. “If anything tries to cross the boundary, don’t handle it on your own. Tell me at once, and I’ll come back immediately.”

Agatha lowered her head and said: “I understand, Captain.”

Alice’s gaze went back and forth between Duncan and Agatha a few times. At last she could not help breaking the silence: “So are we still going into

the city?”

“The Nameless One’s dream is spreading through Lightwind Harbor. To solve this, we still need to look for clues in the city-state first,” Duncan nodded. “I also have many questions I want to test in the city… Do you want to stay on the ship or come with me?”

Alice thought for a moment, then looked back toward the familiar ‘friends’ in the kitchen. After a short pause, she turned back with a bright smile.

“Let’s go to the city together!”

Chapter 581: Before the Dreamwalking

After leaving Sara Mell's residence, Lucretia did not return at once to her own place in the city. Instead, she went back to the Radiant Star, which was moored in the harbor.

A swirl of colorful paper scraps spun over the deck, along the corridor, and across the bridge, then flew into the captain's cabin. Lucretia's figure stepped out of the Phantom Wind. She casually set the bottle of spiced wine on a low cabinet beside her, then walked toward the dressing table where the scrying crystal sat.

In one corner of the room, the large stuffed rabbit doll lying on the bed suddenly moved. It jumped off the bed and hopped this way, calling out: "Mistress! You finally came back, Rabby was so bored on the ship…"

"I just came back for a bit. I still have to return to the city later," Lucretia glanced at the rather creepy stuffed rabbit doll and asked casually: "Any anomaly on the ship?"

"There's no anomaly on the ship, everything is~ just~ fine!" a playful girl's voice came from inside the rabbit, full of pride. "Rabby took good care of everything here, just like when Mistress is on board!"

"What about last night?" Lucretia asked again. "While we were docked in the harbor, did you see anything strange on shore?"

“On shore?” Rabby froze for a moment. It finally seemed to notice the serious look on its mistress’s face, and its playful pride quickly faded. “On shore… nothing seemed wrong, but Rabby didn’t pay much attention to what was happening there…”

Lucretia slowly frowned. After asking the stuffed rabbit doll a few more simple questions, she waved her hand and said: “That’s all for now. Go wait to the side first—later you and Lunie will come into the city with me.”

“Into the city?!” Rabby let out a short gasp, full of both surprise and joy. “You’re taking Rabby into the city? Are we going to play?”

Lucretia reached toward the scrying crystal in front of her. After hearing the stuffed rabbit doll’s words, she stayed silent for a second or two. Then, as her fingers touched the crystal, she said calmly: “For you, it might be fun.”

Rabby instantly jumped up in place with joy, then hopped back onto the bed. With a soft thump, it lay down exactly where it had been and began to wait patiently.

The scrying crystal slowly gave off light and a faint hum. After a while, a response finally came from within that glow. Tyrian’s figure hurriedly appeared in the light and grew clear.

“Lucy?” A voice came from the crystal. “Ah, I was just meeting several merchant delegates and didn’t notice the crystal—how are things on your side?”

“I’m fine.” Lucretia looked at her elder brother in the crystal. When she noticed the weariness on his face, she quietly put away the impatience she had felt from waiting so long. “It looks busy over there. You haven’t been resting much lately?”

“Honestly, things are already much better than before. At least I have a chance to finish my lunch at the table now,” Tyrian shrugged. Then he could

not help glancing at the scene behind Lucretia, as if checking whether a certain person was in the picture. After a brief pause, he hesitated and asked: “Is Father… there with you?”

“Not right now. He’s busy with something else,” Lucretia answered, then added: “Stop being so nervous, Dad is very busy these days.”

“Oh.” Tyrian answered, then hesitated again and asked carefully: “These two days… how have you been getting along with him? Nothing happened, right? Do you need my help with anything?”

“Everything is fine,” Lucretia said casually. Then she thought for a moment and subtly turned her head so that the silver-white sea waves and feathered hair clip came into view. “He finally gave me this hair clip that’s a hundred years late. Somehow, it still looks brand new.”

Tyrian in the crystal froze. The worried look on his face stiffened. He stared blankly for a long moment before the corner of his mouth finally twitched: “…Huh?”

“He didn’t bring you a gift?” Lucretia turned her face back and asked very seriously.

Tyrian thought for a moment, pressed one hand to his forehead, and spoke in a tone of utter despair: “Sixteen shots of twenty?four pounders, three shots of thirty?two pounders, and I didn’t count the twelve pounders…”

Lucretia looked at him in silence for a long time before speaking softly: “You fired first.”

“…You called me just to say that?”

“Of course not.” Lucretia shook her head and finally spoke in a more serious tone: “I want you to pay attention to a few things in the near future. If anything happens, contact me at once.”

Tyrian became serious at once: “Pay attention to what?”

“Elves,” Lucretia said calmly. “If I remember correctly, Frostholm also has many elves who live there long term. The collaborative monitoring system between the Church, the Adventurers’ Association, and the city-state was just set up, and it hasn’t reacted yet, so I’m contacting you directly…”

…

At 99 Crown Street, in the back garden wrapped in trees, greenery, and walls that gave it a rather gloomy air, a burst of fire suddenly spread into a blazing doorway. Duncan and Alice stepped out of the gate.

Shirley, who had been spacing out while basking in the Sun in the backyard, jumped up at once and turned to run into the house—but after only two steps Duncan called her back: “What are you running for?”

Shirley stopped at once and froze in place. She turned her head and scratched her hair: “Right, what am I running for… Sorry, Captain, it was just reflex…”

“Always jumping at shadows,” Duncan frowned at the young lady. “Has Lucretia come back yet?”

“Not yet,” Shirley shook her head. “But Vanna and the old gentleman are back. They’re in the sitting room.”

Duncan nodded: “Good. Come in with me and let’s see what they found.”

“I’ll put these in the kitchen first,” Alice said as she walked off, holding a big wooden basin full of ingredients she had brought from the Vanished. “We can have fish soup tonight!”

Duncan gave the Doll a strange look. It seemed that inside Alice’s head there was a steady little logic tree of her own. No matter how big things became around her, as long as the Vanished didn’t blow up on the spot, she

could calmly follow her own rhythm—going back to the Vanished to fetch fish, heading to the kitchen to cook…

Duncan even suddenly suspected that even if the Vanished really did explode right there, as long as he was still standing in front of this Doll, she would, after reacting, still stare blankly and ask what he wanted for dinner that night.

But that was not a bad thing. In this restless world, Duncan felt it was actually nice to have a Doll at his side who always only cared about what kind of soup they would simmer that night.

A short while later, Duncan arrived in the sitting room. Vanna and Morris, who had just finished a day of work in the city, were reporting what they had learned.

"…As things look now, the whole city-state seems to have been affected last night. That includes the local elven residents and the other races living in the city—no one noticed the change. As for the people who work at night, there seems to be a certain degree of 'cognitive confusion'…"

Vanna sat on the sofa and gave her report from the point of view of a professional inquisitor.

"In the morning I spoke with several artificers who had just come home from their shift at the steam pump house," she continued. "During our talks, I found they didn't remember the details of their night watch work last night, yet they still felt that everything had been normal and nothing had happened all night. Their minds were clear, but they had no awareness of the contradictions in their own words, as if…"

Vanna hesitated, as if searching for the right words, then went on: "As if they were still steeped in a 'waking dream'."

“So you’re saying that the people who were asleep at night all went through a dreamless night, while the people who worked at night ‘lost’ a piece of time out of nowhere and yet still felt everything was normal?” Duncan could not help asking as he listened to Vanna’s report. “Did you try to check the deeper layers of their mental state? Any signs of spiritual corruption?”

“I used some divine magic from the Deep Sea Church, but didn’t push it too far,” Vanna nodded. “After a first check, there are no signs of corruption on them. They just… ‘naturally formed wrong perceptions and memories’.”

Duncan rubbed his chin, thought for a moment, then raised his head and looked at Morris, who sat on the other sofa.

“I went to see a few old friends and told them about last night’s change. The academy has already begun its own investigation and is working on countermeasures. If Miss Lucretia’s side goes smoothly, the whole official response system of Lightwind Harbor will start moving,” Morris nodded. “But from what we know now, once the influence of the Nameless One’s dream grows stronger, everyone in the city-state will be affected. The only ones who can stay clear-headed and act inside or outside the dream will be you and those of us who follow you—and the academy and the city authorities won’t find it easy to move.

“Besides that, I also found several scholars who know elven traditional culture and legends well. I asked them for more details about the Great Demon God Saslokar, the world tree Atlantis, and the ‘Dream of Creation’. During that, I discovered something… rather interesting.”

Duncan grew curious at once: “Something interesting?”

“Yes,” Morris nodded. “In some narrative poems that few people know, there is a passage that goes like this—

‘Saslokar created the world’s first dream, yet He did not know what a dream was;

Mortals named it a dream, and so He became confused;

And then the Dreamless were born from His confusion…’”

Chapter 582: Gradually Gathering Intelligence

As he listened to the lines Morris had recorded from a passage of an ancient elven narrative poem, Duncan's expression grew thoughtful.

"Because of how long ago it was, crossing from the Age of Darkness to the time before the Age of City-States, these lines went through translation from ancient tongues and later repair and additions by scholars. They probably don't restore the original record one hundred percent, but I believe they still have a great deal of meaning," Morris went on. "They should be very helpful for our understanding of the Dream of Creation, and of the current phenomenon of the 'Nameless One's Dream'."

Duncan rubbed his chin, thinking as he said: "Saslokar created all things within dreams, yet did not know what a dream was… How do you think we should understand this line?"

Morris thought for a moment: "In my view, it may refer to the difference between a deity's perspective on the world and that of mortals, or perhaps to some special quality of Saslokar, the 'first Dreamwalking one' in the elven creation myth. For a deity who wandered in dreams, the boundary between dreams and the Mortal Realm might not have had any meaning at all. To Him, the Mortal Realm might have been nothing more than a dream that could be altered at any time, while dreams could at any moment be used to replace the Mortal Realm. That is why He 'did not know what a dream was'…"

“That is… a fairly reasonable explanation,” Duncan nodded slowly. “What about the later lines?”

“As for the last two lines, elven scholars actually have their own interpretations,” Morris answered. “They believe they refer to the day the Great Demon God Saslokar came to understand that the ‘elves’ He had created held a different understanding of the dreamscape. For the first time, He began to doubt the boundary between the Mortal Realm and dreams. That may have been a kind of ‘crisis’. In the midst of it, Saslokar almost ‘woke up’, and in that unstable state He created the group among the elves known as ‘the Dreamless’.”

“The Dreamless…” Duncan nodded slightly. “I remember the elves regard that as an inborn defect.”

“Yes. That fits the legends exactly. The Dreamless were born at a time when Saslokar was in an unstable state. They were the result of the Creator’s ‘daze’, and so they were flawed, doomed never to enter the ‘paradise of dreams’. However…”

Morris paused there, thought for a moment, then went on: “But precisely because of this, in a very small number of legends there is also a claim that Saslokar is in fact the patron god of the Dreamless. That reading has very little acceptance in elven society. It is somewhat better in modern times; in the ancient era it was basically considered heresy.”

“Saslokar as the patron of the Dreamless…” Vanna muttered nearby. “If I am not wrong, that must have been put forward when the Dreamless were suffering social discrimination and oppression and huddling together for warmth. Maybe at first it was only meant to give their own group some spiritual support.”

“Exactly so,” Morris nodded. “That idea first appeared in the Dark Age, and spread on certain ‘exile islands’ under the control of the elven city-states. At

that time the elves believed the Dreamless were people afflicted by the curse. Their innate defect would cause ‘Great Hollows’ to appear in the dreamscape, which in turn drew nightmares and Shadows that devoured the heart. So they exiled their flawed kin to isolated islands on the edge of the civilized world…

“In those settlements far from the core of civilization, the first claims that ‘Saslokar is the patron of the Dreamless’ appeared. The exiles used that belief as a support to help them endure the hard and endless Long Night.

“Later, as the times changed and the influence of the faith in the Four Gods grew, and as the exile lands themselves gradually rose in power, this practice of exile was slowly abolished. The ‘special cultures’ that had arisen in those exile lands also flowed back into mainstream elven society. But clearly, although the mainstream could accept the kin who had once been exiled, it could not accept those ‘heretical’ cultures of theirs…”

Duncan listened in silence. In his mind he could not help linking this information with the recent Anomaly incident in Lightwind Harbor and the scattered clues. The pieces of information rearranged themselves in his head, and faintly he felt as if he was about to touch that most crucial chain of logic.

But he still lacked some more effective points of reference, some more useful intelligence…

While he was thinking, a familiar presence suddenly appeared within his senses.

From the direction of the entrance hall came the sound of a servant opening the door and offering a greeting, followed by approaching footsteps. A moment later, Lucretia’s figure appeared in the sitting room.

The clockwork doll Lunie followed behind Lucretia. The doll, dressed as a maid, held in her arms an especially large cloth stuffed rabbit doll with a bizarre and unsettling look.

In the next second, that bizarre, creepy stuffed rabbit doll suddenly twitched. Then it quickly jumped down from Lunie's arms to the floor, bouncing as it let out a shrill voice: "Finally here, finally here! Rabby has finally come into the city! Today Rabby is going to make a big—"

Duncan silently watched the stuffed rabbit doll, and the other gazes in the room also fell one after another on that eerie rabbit.

The strange toy that had been hopping around the sitting room a heartbeat earlier, loudly declaring it was going to cause a commotion, instantly froze. It slowly lifted its head, the button-sewn eyes checking the situation in the room. After two or three seconds it finally shivered, then slowly walked over to the corner farthest from Duncan. With a soft plop it sat down and began pretending to be a real little doll.

It all happened very quickly. Nina and Shirley, sitting across from Duncan, did not even understand what had just happened.

Two seconds later, Lucretia's voice finally broke the silence in the sitting room: "Don't mind it. It is sometimes not very well-behaved, so I rarely bring it into the city."

Then she turned to Duncan and nodded with a slight smile: "But with you here, Rabby should be better behaved than ever before."

The doll Lunie also stepped forward and bowed to Duncan: "Good day, Old Master."

After greeting him, the clockwork doll lifted her head, as if searching for something nearby.

“Alice is in the kitchen,” Duncan could not help but laugh. “If you want to find her, go ahead.”

Lunie turned her head to confirm once more with her mistress. After receiving permission, she happily left the sitting room.

Duncan’s gaze then fell on Lucretia: “Did everything go smoothly?”

“Everything went smoothly. I have already met with Sara Mell, then went back to the Radiant Star once more and mentioned to Tyrian what happened here…”

Listening to Lucretia recount her actions for the day, Duncan nodded slightly, then let out a long breath.

“Good. I understand the general situation. Since everyone is here now… it is time I told you what I have found on my side.”

Everyone in the sitting room instinctively adjusted their posture at once. Even Shirley, who had been nodding off a little just now, instantly perked up.

They had heard something different in the captain’s tone.

Duncan did not keep them in suspense. He quickly told them what he knew so far, especially his guesses concerning “Goathead”.

However, he did not speak much about the odd “details” aboard the Vanished. That part would only heighten everyone else’s unease and would be of no real help at this stage in dealing with the anomaly in Lightwind Harbor.

The mere conjecture that there might be a connection between Goathead and Saslokar was already enough to plunge the entire room into dead silence.

For a long time after Duncan finished outlining the situation, no one spoke.

Everyone stared at one another in bewilderment, until Nina broke the silence: “That Goathead who nags all day long… could be connected to the ‘Great Demon God Saslokar’ from elven legends? Isn’t that a bit…”

“It is an outlandish conjecture, but at present several clues seem to point in that direction,” Duncan said seriously. “Goathead himself does not know his own origin. That eerie ship, the Vanished, which sails through the mist, just happened to appear at midnight, when the influence of the Nameless One’s Dream is at its strongest. On the door of the captain’s cabin of that ship are written the words ‘May He wander in dreams’—a phrase that clearly connects to ancient elven legends. Add to that the suspicious Goathead aboard that ship, his strange condition, and his odd reaction when Atlantis was mentioned… All of this cannot be a coincidence.”

Lucretia’s expression shifted rapidly, an unusual, heavy unease appearing in her eyes. She could not help glancing at her father several times before she finally spoke, hesitant: “Goathead… I remember you said it was a being from Subspace. Leaving aside why the ‘god of creation’ from ancient elven legends would have become like that, even if Goathead really is connected to ‘Saslokar’, then how would the Vanished…”

She stopped, as if unable to find suitable words to go on. After several seconds she finally continued: “How did the Vanished end up entangled with all of this?”

Duncan noticed the source of Lucretia’s unease.

She was speaking about the Vanished—yet all of her tension seemed to fall upon herself.

“Don’t be afraid, Lucy. Nothing has entered a runaway state,” Duncan said slowly. His voice was steady, carrying a reassuring strength. “Subspace holds too many secrets. Even I cannot say clearly how much it has affected the Vanished. But one thing is certain: as long as I still possess my

humanity, that ship will not enter a runaway state again. And right now, I am very clear?headed."

"Right, right, right," Shirley hurried to speak. The shocking news she had just heard had made her whole body tense. Hearing Duncan's words now, she seemed to be bolstering her own courage as she blurted out: "With the captain around, that ship can't go wrong. The captain, he even has human nature…"

Duncan was speechless: "…?"

Several gazes around them instantly focused on Shirley, but she still had not realized it and kept talking: "the Vanished does have some odd places about it normally, but…"

Dog finally emerged from the Shadows beside the sofa and slapped a paw down on Shirley's head: "Shut up!"

Chapter 583: The Need for a Capture Operation

In any case, Shirley’s thoughtless interruption did succeed in easing the tense, heavy atmosphere in the sitting room—though the mood had nearly been dragged off in another direction.

Duncan had a hard time forcing his expression back under control. Then he ignored Shirley, who had realized what she said and almost curled herself into a ball to squeeze into the gap in the sofa, and cleared his throat twice as he said: “Anyway, for now this is all the intelligence we have. The fog is still thick, but it is very clear that the Vanished has already become part of this vortex. That is different from what happened before in Pland and Frostholm.

“No matter how things develop next, I have to figure out what exactly this so?called Nameless One’s Dream is, and what those cultists’ goals really are—especially the second point.

“Annihilators, Suntists, and the Enders hiding behind them—no matter which kind, if we can take them alive, we take them alive. If we cannot, we still have to find ways to gather as much intelligence as possible when we engage them… The Nameless One’s Dream will not simply fade away. It will definitely appear again, and as long as this vortex continues, we cannot avoid further dealings with those cultists.”

At this point Duncan suddenly stopped. He glanced thoughtfully at Shirley, who sat on the sofa with her head lowered, trying her best to reduce her

presence, and at Dog, lying beside her.

Shirley instantly felt the gaze fall on her. She jolted and jerked her head up: “I’m sorry, Captain, I shouldn’t have said you have human nature just now…”

“Did you and Dog sense the aura of that fleeing Annihilator today?” Duncan waved his hand, cutting off her reflexive rambling. “I remember you said that when you encountered him before in the Nameless One’s Dream, Dog left a ‘mark’ on that cultist.”

“No.” Before Shirley could answer, Dog was already shaking his head. “I’ve been paying attention to that all day, but as far as I can tell, that cultist does not seem to be in Lightwind Harbor.”

“This time these aberrant cultists are hiding in lairs scattered across the city?states, relying only on entering the Nameless One’s Dream to ‘coordinate their actions’. That indeed makes it very hard for us to catch them in the Mortal Realm,” Vanna added. “Even worse, they clearly have already grasped some of the ‘rules’ of the Nameless One’s Dream. That allows them to move in and out of that ‘dream’ freely, which makes them even harder to deal with.”

Vanna’s words made Duncan frown as well. It was indeed vexing to know that the cultists were moving everywhere, yet, because of a lack of intelligence and an overly cunning enemy, have no easy way to act. And for Duncan, his troubles at this moment did not stop there—

He had once actually managed to “capture” an Annihilator who had entered a Dreamwalking state, and had even used that cultist’s eyes to locate a hideout where a cult gathering was taking place. But he had been unable to expand on that success. The keen senses of the Abyssal demons and the fragile ecology of the symbiotic pacts of the Annihilators meant those

cultists simply could not withstand his power. Before he could extract much information, those people died, clean and swift.

Every time he recalled it, he felt regret.

He let himself feel that regret for a moment, then his gaze finally fell on Dog.

“Is my power very conspicuous to you?” he asked.

Dog was startled by the captain’s sudden question, and his head drooped at once: “When you put it like that… is it supposed to be conspicuous… or not conspicuous…”

“I want to know how to keep other Abyssal demons from sensing my power,” Duncan ignored Dog’s hopelessly cowardly reaction and went on seriously. “Sometimes I can successfully leave my mark on an Annihilator, but the Abyssal demons bound to them in symbiotic pacts quickly detect my power. That has already caused me more than one problem.”

“Well…” Dog’s tone instantly turned a bit odd. “That’s rather hard. The senses of Abyssal demons are extremely keen by nature, and except for me, Abyssal demons lack reason and act only on instinct. Seeking benefit and avoiding harm, that’s their greatest instinct. Faced with tremendous danger, abandoning their symbiotic pact partners and fleeing back to the Abyssal Deep Sea, is the choice they will inevitably make, unless…”

Duncan raised his eyebrows: “Unless?”

“Unless their symbiotic pact is cut off completely, or the demons are brought under control ahead of time, before they can react,” Dog said, thinking as he spoke. “The first method is almost impossible, because this kind of symbiotic pact is irreversible. It gradually reshapes the symbiotic pact partner’s physiology. Once the initial phase is over, breaking that chain is enough in itself to kill the symbiotic pact partner.

“As for the second method… it is somewhat feasible, but not easy to carry out. It mainly requires prior preparation, yet different Abyssal demons have different traits, so it is very hard to prepare in advance a truly thorough, ‘targeted’ plan for seizing control in an instant…”

Dog rambled on for quite a while, then paused as if something had occurred to him. He raised his head to look at Duncan: “But we don’t necessarily have to catch Annihilators. Aren’t there other cultists active as well? The Enders are hard to catch. The Suntists are much easier…”

Without realizing it, Dog had already started subconsciously treating those elusive cultists as prey that could be “ordered and caught on demand”, as if, so long as the captain wanted to take them, no matter how well the cultists hid, they would sooner or later fall into his hands.

However, Duncan shook his head: “It would be best if we can still capture some Annihilators.”

“Huh?” Shirley froze for a moment beside him. “Why?”

Duncan thought for a moment, his face serious: “I have a use for them.”

Everyone looked blank.

Seeing this, Duncan hesitated slightly, then raised his hand and lightly drew it through the air.

Water?like spirit form flames rippled out at his side and, in the blink of an eye, spread through the entire sitting room. As the flame burned, an invisible power seeped into the Mortal Realm, blurring the boundary between the Mortal Realm and the Spirit Realm. Duncan’s body rapidly shifted toward a spirit form state.

“Praise be to the name of Rahm—” As soon as he saw this, Morris said a quick benediction, then layered a whole stack of miscellaneous mental protections onto himself.

Vanna, beside him, also moved with practiced ease, taking a storm amulet and a pocket rosary from her bosom. As she recited Gamona's name, she blessed herself.

A faint radiance of the Sun appeared in Nina's eyes as she looked at her Uncle Duncan with an eager expression. Dog let out an "Oh crap!" and his figure vanished in an instant into the depths of the Shadows. Shirley reacted half a beat slower and only had time to raise her hands to cover her ears: "In a moment, can I maybe not listen to this…"

"I intend to establish a connection with the Abyssal Lord—by using the power of those Annihilators."

Duncan's voice came with the crackling of the flame as he spoke calmly. Then he glanced at the people around him with a bit of helplessness: "Do you really have to go this far?"

Shirley lowered the hands covering her ears: "…My head is buzzing."

"You're just nervous," Duncan glanced at her. "I've already put proper protections in place. There is no need for you to be so tense."

"Caution never hurts," Morris said calmly from the opposite sofa. "Of course we trust your power, but we are all fragile mortals in the end. Please understand…"

Vanna nodded as well to show she agreed with Morris. But then a trace of puzzlement appeared as she looked at Duncan: "But if it's just that, you could have just told us. That reason itself isn't dangerous. For us, mentioning the words 'Abyssal Lord' from time to time isn't such a big deal…"

"Because this suggestion was given to me personally by the Abyssal Lord," Duncan said casually. "He established contact with me deep inside Alice's

manor, and the suggestion itself is the power He is sending to the Mortal Realm…”

He had barely gotten the first part out when Shirley quickly clapped her hands over her ears. After a sharp smack, she lowered her arms with a mournful look: “I let my guard down… My head really is buzzing.”

Duncan gave her a blank look and did not bother to reply.

Meanwhile, Lucretia, sitting not far away, had not caught up at all since just now. The young witch stared, dumbfounded, at the rapidly unfolding scene before her. Her eyes had followed every step, but her mind had not kept up with a single one.

After a few seconds she finally reacted belatedly, staring dumbly at Vanna and Morris: “You two… look very practiced at this…”

“The captain often discusses profound Truths with us,” Morris said with a dignified nod. “We have our own standard procedure for talking about such matters.”

Lucretia’s expression was a little blank. Her gaze swept over the sitting room, which looked eerie and shadowy under the reflection of the spirit flame. Then she finally realized what her father had just said. She immediately looked to Duncan, her eyes opening slightly wider: “Wait, you just said… the Abyssal Lord made contact with you, and He suggested… suggested that you go and capture His believers?”

Duncan nodded: “I was very surprised as well, but that’s how it is.”

Lucretia thought it over and still could not make sense of it.

The “Sea Witch” was well?traveled and knowledgeable—but she truly had never seen anything like this.

Still, there was someone present who was calmly thinking the matter through. After his initial shock, Morris quickly realized the astonishing amount of information hidden behind this “suggestion”.

He quickly checked the divine blessings and wards on himself, then asked Duncan to confirm more details behind this “suggestion”, verifying all kinds of particulars the Abyssal Lord had revealed while communicating with the captain.

Duncan, for his part, finally had a chance to share this incredible event with his followers. He had long wanted to speak of it, but the sudden coming of the Nameless One’s Dream had delayed his plan.

After a long time, Duncan finally finished recounting his experiences deep within Alice’s manor. Morris, sitting opposite him, had fallen into deep thought.

“…Unbelievable. One of the most dangerous Elder Gods in this world actually still retains sanity, and even made such an astonishing ‘suggestion’ to you…” the old mister muttered in his thoughts. “If we really can establish a stable and safe connection with this Elder God, then we might truly be able to understand several of the greatest mysteries in this world, even… truly understand the birth of the Age of the Deep Sea…”

Shirley scratched her hair: “So?”

Morris suddenly turned his head and looked into Shirley’s eyes. The old scholar, who usually appeared so refined and gentle, now had a blazing intensity in his gaze that inspired awe—

“We follow the captain’s words and capture a few Annihilators to try it,” he said, his eyes shining with the scholar’s eagerness to peer into the Truth. “At this point, this matter has risen to the level of academic research!”

Chapter 584

Clearly, Morris was now burning with a fierce passion to search for truth. In this old gentleman's eyes, those cultists who scared ordinary people had probably already turned into stacks of walking papers and research materials.

"So the only question is how we drag those Annihilators who enter the Nameless One's dream out of the Mortal Realm," Vanna said. She looked at the energetic old gentleman beside her and quietly shifted a little to the side. "Tomorrow I'll contact the Church and see if we can tighten surveillance and manhunts for Annihilators in every city-state. If they have to keep entering the Nameless One's dream and they share command and information, they will be much more active than usual."

Morris also nodded: "I'll remind the Academy as well… though they probably don't need the reminder."

They discussed ways to flush those cultists out in the Mortal Realm. At that moment, Lucretia, who had been quietly thinking, suddenly raised her head and looked at Shirley and Dog: "If it's inside the Nameless One's dream, can you still find that cultist from last time?"

"That depends on whether he's nearby, and whether he even dares to enter the Nameless One's dream again." Dog shook his head. "Last time, Shirley and I badly hurt that Annihilator. It didn't damage his body in the Mortal Realm, but his mind won't recover in a short time."

Lucretia listened and nodded thoughtfully. No one knew what was going through her mind.

Outside the window, the Sun had slowly sunk behind the buildings at the edge of the block. The last crimson glow spread along the rows of rooftops. Golden sunlight spread from the distant sea and mixed into the fading evening clouds.

Nina suddenly lifted her head and looked at the sky growing dim outside the window. She muttered softly: “It’s getting dark again…”

Her soft words broke Duncan’s thoughts. He rose from the sofa, walked to the window, and quietly gazed at the street outside.

The “knowledge guards” of Truth Academy were already preparing for the shift change at dusk. In front of the security post on the corner, a squad of guardians was talking with the constables.

There were twice as many guardians today as on normal days. Among them were upper-ranked clerics with much better gear. They were probably elite forces transferred from the central university of the city-state.

A loudspeaker truck drove past on the road, urging citizens to finish outdoor activities and go home before the gas lamps lit up. Tonight’s curfew would start an hour earlier. The broadcast repeated the warning: if any citizens could not make it home in time, they should go to the nearest guardian post at once. The Academy would send people and vehicles to escort them back as fast as possible.

Farther away, the tall spire of the clock tower bathed in crossed sunlight and sunset glow. The golden-red light seemed to coat the tower in a crystal shell. Huge steam pipes stretched from both sides of the tower and puffed out thin white mist, warming up to ring the dusk Bell.

The city-state’s authority and the Academy had not announced any emergency. But in the eyes of those who knew what was really going on, the change in the air showed in many small details.

“They’re preparing for tonight,” Vanna also walked over and said softly beside Duncan. “Even though there is still no proof that the Nameless One’s dream will appear again tonight…”

“We don’t know what preparations they’ve made, or whether those preparations will actually work.” Duncan shook his head. “So far we still know nothing about how that ‘dream’ works. We only know it may be tied to some trait of the entire race of Elves. In that area, we can’t help them.”

“We have many problems of our own to solve.” Vanna’s tone grew more serious. “If the Nameless One’s dream appears again, we still don’t know what will happen. We might be scattered and swept into Dreamwalking again. We might arrive in different places than before. We might meet enemies, or step straight into those dangerous areas they call ‘corruption zones’.”

Duncan said nothing. He slowly turned around and let his gaze sweep across the living room.

The others had already gathered. Many eyes rested on him.

After a short pause, Duncan stretched out his hand with his palm facing up.

ghostly green flame surged and rolled beside him, turning his body into a phantom spirit form as if cast from fire. His eyes focused on his palm. The fire of his spirit form gathered there and slowly became the brightest, most lively little flame.

Duncan held up the weightless flame. Amid the faint crackle and pop, his voice reached everyone: “Come here and touch this fire.”

Everyone in the living room reacted in different ways, but most of all with unavoidable shock and hesitation.

Of course they were not strangers to the captain's fire. In fact, they had already come into contact with this spirit form flame more than once and to different degrees. But instinct was hard to fight and oddly stubborn. This little flame was far more active and bright than the "gentle" fire they usually saw on the Vanished. That tiny difference made them tense without even realizing it.

But Nina was the first to walk over. There was even a bit of expectation on her face. She looked up at her "Uncle Duncan", and her usual bright smile appeared.

Then she reached out and lightly touched the flame in Duncan's palm with her index finger.

Thin strands of fire wrapped around her fingertip like water and then quietly faded.

"It's nice and warm." Nina laughed and waved at Shirley. "Your turn!"

"Yeah, yeah…" Shirley grumbled. She dragged her feet as she took two steps forward. She reached out her hand while muttering: "The captain wouldn't hurt me anyway…"

Duncan nodded to Shirley with a gentle look, then added: "Dog needs it too."

Dog, who had just been about to turn away, jolted. He raised his head to stare at the flame, and his blood-red eye sockets seemed filled with solid fear: "I… I don't really need it, right…"

"You do." Duncan looked seriously at this Abyssal demon. "Don't worry. It's just a harmless temporary mark. Without my command, this fire won't harm you at all."

Dog still hesitated: “I…”

Before he could finish, Duncan flipped his hand over and pressed it down on Dog’s head, rubbing hard at that rough, solid skull.

Pale green flame poured down over him from above and flickered through the bony body of the Abyssal Hound.

Dog’s whole body shuddered at once, and he only had time to yelp: “Oh crap—”

Duncan ignored him and looked up at the others.

Vanna and Morris also stepped forward. Each recited a prayer to their own deity, then touched the flame in the captain’s hand with solemn faces.

Now there was only one person left.

“Lucy.” Duncan looked calmly at the “sea witch” standing not far away. “Don’t worry. This is just a special mark. If the Nameless One’s dream appears again, the power inside the mark may help you.”

“I know.” Lucretia spoke softly, with a faint, complicated look in her eyes. She looked up at her Father standing there as a hazy spirit form in the flames and at the bright, dancing flame in his palm. After a few seconds, she finally stepped forward and slowly reached her hand toward Duncan: “…Is this the power of Subspace?”

Duncan looked at her calmly: “This is my power.”

Lucretia took a slow breath, then stepped up and touched the fire.

There was no pain, no burning, none of the corruption or mental disturbance she had expected. She only felt a calm warmth, gentle and soothing.

A ghostly green light flashed in Lucretia’s eyes.

Then the “sea witch” turned around, hurried to the corner of the room, grabbed the huge stuffed rabbit doll, and brought it back to Duncan.

The stuffed rabbit doll, which had been playing dead for most of the day, finally moved. It twisted hard in Lucretia’s hand, and a little girl’s terrified voice came from its cotton-filled body: “Mistress, what are you doing! Rabby is just a rabbit! Rabby is just—”

“Quiet.” Lucretia pinched the stuffed rabbit’s back hard, making the creepy little doll fall silent at once. Then she held it out. “Dad, give Rabby a mark.”

At first Duncan did not react. When he saw Lucretia bring the stuffed rabbit over, he had already wondered why. Only now did he faintly guess: “Is this… because you want to take this doll into the Nameless One’s dream?”

“Rabby can move around in dreams—it does dream,” Lucretia said. “I want to see if, when the Nameless One’s dream expands, it will also get pulled into the dream. Before, when the Radiant Star stayed in the Harbor, Rabby said it did not sense anything strange in the city at all. That might be because the Harbor was too far from the center of the dream’s outbreak, or because Rabby was affected too little by your power.”

The stuffed rabbit doll struggled again and let out a tiny voice: “If Rabby had known, Rabby wouldn’t have come…”

Lucretia raised her hand and pressed the rabbit’s face against Duncan’s palm.

Duncan said nothing.

He suddenly felt like a training dummy that did nothing but hand out buffs… This was not quite how he had planned it, was it?

But anyway, he had finished all the preparations before Dreamwalking. Next… he only had to wait and see whether the Nameless One’s dream

would really appear again tonight, and test his many guesses and plans inside that dream.

Just then, footsteps came from the doorway of the living room. Alice and Lunie appeared in Duncan’s sight, pushing a serving cart.

“Dinner time!” Alice said happily. She seemed completely unaware of the mood in the living room. “Are we eating in the dining room, or right here in the living room?”

Chapter 585

In the end, the doll Lunie also let Alice pull her over to receive the flame mark granted by the captain.

By then, everyone in this “witch’s mansion” had received the brand of the spirit form flame before Dreamwalking, except for the simpler tin men and puppets that did not have complete minds.

Dinner time came. Bright electric lights and the gas lamps on the walls lit the wide dining room. The members of the Lost Home Fleet gathered around the long table, sharing fish, bread, and wine as they prepared to face the coming, deeper, and more unpredictable veil of night.

Faint, ghostly green flames jumped in the depths of their eyes. Their gazes seemed to look at both the Mortal Realm and a second, unreal layer at the same time. A trace of the captain’s power mixed into their voices as they talked, making a low buzzing vibration in the air. The ghost-green flame also seeped into the gas lamps on the walls, so every flame carried a hint of green light. Under that glow, the walls and floor of the dining room took on a strange texture, as if they were part of a spirit form.

If some ordinary person who knew nothing walked into the dining room at this moment by accident, the eerie atmosphere and power here would soak into them at once. It would be very hard for them to keep their reason and sense of self.

The clockwork doll Lunie lit the decorative candelabras. Candlelight flickered over the table. The pale yellow flames reflected on the silver and

ceramic cups and plates, giving off a warm, enchanting glow.

Morris and Lucretia spoke in low voices about ancient legends tied to elven society. Their talk was full of technical terms that would be hard for any ordinary person to follow. Shirley was gulping down her food. She was always the first one at the table to fill her stomach. Vanna was saying the blessing before the meal. She was still the most devout one and always carried out the Goddess's rite carefully, no matter the situation. Nina, after eating a few bites, quietly lifted her head. Her eyes shifted toward the wine set not far in front of her.

"I want to drink some fermented grape juice…"

A fragment of the ancient Sun made a request to the Flame Usurper.jpg.

Duncan glanced at the young lady and raised his eyebrows: "Why aren't you saying you want some wheat juice this time?"

Nina's eyes lit up at once. She reached toward the beer on the other side: "Really?"

Duncan looked at her without expression: "What do you think?"

"Oh…" Nina muttered. She obediently picked up the lemonade on the other side instead, looking very disappointed.

The mechanical clock in the corner ticked and whirred. Its hands slowly moved forward.

Near the end of dinner, Duncan suddenly broke the silence: "I've actually been thinking about a question."

"What question?" Vanna set down her knife and fork on the other side of the table and asked with curiosity.

"How does the Abyssal Lord really see His believers?" Duncan spoke very seriously. "He suggested I catch some Annihilators to build a link between

me and the Abyssal Deep Sea. He didn’t sound the least bit sorry for them. But He still stayed rational and seemed to care a lot about this world. Don’t you find that strange?”

“I actually think it makes sense.” Morris wiped his mouth and said slowly. “It makes even more sense if we start from the idea that the Abyssal Lord is sane.”

Duncan raised his eyebrows at that: “Oh?”

“Before you managed to make contact with that Elder God, the Abyssal Lord had never spoken with the Mortal Realm at all. In other words, those so-called Annihilators were only worshipping their ‘lord’ on their own.” Morris shrugged. “They used that one-sided faith to draw power and kept summoning demons from the Abyssal Deep Sea, for their own use.

“Think of it from another angle. If you were the Abyssal Lord, and a noisy crowd of mortals suddenly showed up from who-knows-where… they claim to be your descendants, then run into your yard, steal your fruit, dig up your fruit trees, trick away your servants, and in the end, they even want to pry open your front door and move into your rooms…”

Duncan thought about it and felt his blood pressure rise.

“All right, I think I understand…” He sighed. “That does make sense.”

The mechanical clock in the corner of the dining room suddenly rang out the hour. The loud clang-clang-clang cut off the talk at the table and echoed hollowly through the great house.

Duncan listened to the chimes and silently counted each strike. Then he spoke softly: “Nine o’clock.”

No one answered him.

Only a few empty chairs remained on both sides of the table, as if no one had been sitting there from the very start.

Duncan slowly frowned as he looked at the dining room that had suddenly become empty. Even though this change had happened right under his nose, he still had not caught the exact “process” of it.

Everything had happened all at once, as if the whole world had “switched” in a single very short moment. It was like a playing card flipping over. The numbers on the face became the pattern on the back in an instant. Nina, Morris, and the others had gone with the flipping cards into another dimension, while Duncan was still left at the table.

Alice was still “at the table” with Duncan.

The doll miss widened her eyes at once, looking badly startled: “Wow!”

“The Nameless One’s dream really has appeared again…” Duncan slowly rose from his chair. “Even that stuffed rabbit doll is gone.”

As soon as he finished speaking, a slightly nervous voice came from the side: “Old Master, I… I’m still here.”

Duncan and Alice turned their heads at the same time toward the voice.

The clockwork doll Lunie was standing not far behind them. She had been standing there during dinner as well.

Now this clockwork doll had been left on this side of the Mortal Realm.

Alice stared at her in surprise: “Lunie! Why are you left on this side too?!”

“I don’t know.” The clockwork doll spread her hands and shook her head. Then she looked at the empty seats on the other side of the table with worry in her voice: “Mistress… is she all right?”

“They’ve already reached the other side of the dream,” Duncan said. At the same time he could not help but look Lunie over from head to toe, his brow slowly furrowing.

Lunie had been left on “this side”… why?

When the Nameless One’s dream appeared, he and Alice were left on the Mortal Realm side. Now Lunie had also been left here, and she was still awake… What mechanism was working behind this?

Was it because they were… “dolls”?

“Lunie, do you dream?” Duncan asked suddenly as he thought.

“I… don’t know.” Lunie froze for a moment and then answered honestly. “Sometimes, when Mistress maintains my body, I fall into a daze and remember some things from before. But Mistress says that isn’t dreaming. It’s just memories spilling out of the soul container. So maybe I don’t dream? I don’t really know what it is like when humans dream.”

“What about Rabby then? Does that rabbit named Rabby really dream?” Duncan asked again.

“Rabby does dream. In fact, it’s very strong inside dreams,” Lunie said. “Many years ago, Mistress went through a time when nightmares often bothered her. It even started to disturb her research. So Mistress made some preparations and let herself fall into Dreamwalking on purpose, to face the shadows invading her mind. She won, and caught one of those shadows from the deepest part of her nightmare. That shadow came from the Spirit Realm. Mistress said it was a creature of fear. She beat it up again and again, then sewed it into a little doll. That is Rabby…”

Duncan listened as the clockwork doll in front of him calmly told this story. After a moment, the corner of his mouth twitched: “It seems Lucretia has

had quite a few strange experiences over the years… All right, I think I more or less understand."

Alice scratched her head: "Huh?"

"The Nameless One's dream seems to only affect beings that can Dreamwalk." Duncan looked at the two dolls in front of him. "As dolls, you don't really dream. Or even if you 'dream', your dreams are not 'compatible' with those of ordinary people."

Duncan added that careful note at the end because he suddenly remembered how Alice had once told him about some "dream-like" experiences she had while she slept. In a sense, Alice also dreamed. But just like Lunie, her dreams were not the same as those of ordinary people. If he had to describe it… it was more like a doll's daze.

That kind of "daze" clearly did not meet the "standard" for entering the Nameless One's dream.

Alice listened with a half-dazed look. Then, in her not-so-bright head, a sudden idea flashed. She seemed to think of something and stared wide-eyed at Duncan: "Then why are you, Captain, left on this side like us? You don't dream either?"

"Of course I…" Duncan started to answer without thinking. Then he froze, staring with a strange look on his face.

Had he… really dreamed at all after coming to this world?

He meant dreams in the normal sense. Dreams that belonged to a mortal, woven between the Mortal Realm and memory.

It was as if someone had suddenly flipped a switch that had been ignored for a long time. A chaotic corner in his subconscious that he had never noticed before showed itself. For the first time, Duncan paid attention to

this question. He quickly thought back on every time he had fallen asleep since crossing that door into this world, and on… his “dreams”.

He remembered. He had dreamed. In dreams he had entered Subspace. In dreams he had seen coming disasters. He had seen the Sun go out, a dying hollow disk hanging in the sky, and bizarre luminous cores falling from above…

But other than those, he could not remember dreaming of anything else. His current body barely needed sleep at all. The habit of lying in bed every day was, most of the time, only a way for him to keep some sense of “being human”…

Yes, he did dream, though not often, though…

Duncan suddenly raised his hand and pressed hard on his brow.

No. Dreams shouldn’t be like this. They shouldn’t only be like this. Where were the ordinary dreams? The scenes from the day that should appear in sleep afterward? The things that could be called good dreams, the plain dreams, the funny dreams, the dreams full of memories, the dreams that… belonged to ordinary people?

Duncan tried hard to remember. But he suddenly found that all his dreams either led to Subspace or to some “visions” that seemed to cross time and space like prophecies. Aside from those two kinds, every time he slept… there was only nothingness.

It was not only in this world, either.

He thought back.

Zhou Ming thought back.

He remembered the days before he opened the door of that single apartment, the days before he was trapped in that fog, the days long, long

ago—so long ago they seemed like another life—when everything was still normal and the world had not yet fallen into the mist.

Zhou Ming lifted his head in confusion.

Had he… ever dreamed like an ordinary person?

Chapter 586: Desert

The clockwork doll Lunie looked worriedly at Duncan, who had suddenly gone blank. After a few seconds, she could not help turning to Alice beside her and asked: “Old Master, what’s wrong with him?”

Alice only looked as if this was perfectly normal and tried to comfort her new friend: “It’s fine, he’s just spacing out. The Captain zones out all the time…”

Lunie froze for a moment: “Is that so?”

The two dolls’ voices reached Duncan’s ears. He finally blinked and slowly returned from his memories to the Mortal Realm.

After a brief silence, Duncan raised his hand and slowly pinched the spot between his brows, letting his lowered eyelids hide the turmoil in his eyes. Chaotic thoughts still swirled in his mind. He was still recalling the past. He even wished he could dig out every day he could remember, all the way back to the earliest moments of his childhood, and lay them all out before him.

He had finally noticed his dreamless past, noticed that corner of his subconscious he had always ignored. But he had to break free from these tangled memories and thoughts and force his attention back onto the Mortal Realm before him.

He raised his head and looked at Alice, who was staring straight at him, and at the clockwork doll beside her, who still looked a little nervous.

“I’m fine,” Duncan said softly. “I just suddenly remembered some things…”

He paused, looked into Alice’s eyes, and asked: “Where were we just now?”

“We were saying that Lunie and I were probably left on the ‘outside’ of the Nameless One’s dream because dolls don’t dream,” Alice answered at once. “Then we were talking about why you were left out here too…”

“Not dreaming may only be one factor. The mechanism of the Nameless One’s dream won’t be that simple, and it is very likely changing…”

Duncan spoke slowly. At the same time, he recalled the dream that had once trapped Taran Ael, the scholar—

There was no doubt that the dream Taran Ael had fallen into back then had also been the Nameless One’s dream. But that had only been the “shallow layer” of the dream, and the dream itself had still been in its early state. At that time, Duncan had still been able to use the mark he had left on Heidi to enter that dream quite easily, instead of being blocked on the Mortal Realm side as he was now.

This showed that the “rules” of the Nameless One’s dream were changing. As time went on, its range and influence were expanding, and at the same time a Dreamwalking mechanism for “filtering” had formed, like a kind of self?protection.

What would come next? Would this vast “dream” keep growing? Would its reach expand again? How would its self?protection change?

As Duncan pondered, Alice’s voice suddenly sounded beside him and reached his ears: “Captain, how are the others doing? Can you feel anything from here?”

Duncan pushed his messy thoughts down for now. He let out a quiet breath and focused his mind, feeling for the marks he had left on the others—

The leaping flames crossed the border between real and unreal and passed through the ancient, hidden curtain of the dream. In a distant other dimension, at a crossing of time and space that reason could hardly describe, Duncan “saw” those flickering sparks.

The flame marks he had planted in advance had taken effect. They only strengthened the connection a little, but Duncan could now sense Vanna and the others more clearly and should even be able to talk with them.

“They’re not in danger.” Duncan nodded to Alice and Lunie as he spoke.

Alice let out a breath of relief at once: “Ah, that’s good… Then what are we doing next?”

Duncan lifted his head. His gaze passed through the nearby window to the street outside, now shrouded in the chaotic veil of night.

That strange sight had appeared outside the window again. As the Nameless One’s dream pushed into the Mortal Realm, lush forest plants once more covered the city?state. Endless towering canopies blocked out the sky. The districts under the giant trees were dim and hazy, a blend of real and unreal.

Lightwind Harbor had already fallen silent. The world after Dreamwalking had replaced the Mortal Realm, just as Duncan had expected. The rushed preparations of the city?state’s authority and the academy’s Guardians had not done much. Now, once again, only he and Alice were awake in this city.

Oh, and this time there was also a clockwork doll.

“We’re going to where that vine appeared last time,” Duncan said calmly as he turned and walked toward the front door of the house. “We’ll see if it shows up in the same place.”

“All right!” Alice agreed at once. She reached out and grabbed Lunie, who was still a little dazed. “Come on, come on, we’re going exploring with the Captain!”

“Exploring?” Lunie followed Alice and Duncan on instinct, but her mind was clearly still a bit behind the pace. “What are we going to do?”

“We’re going to look for the other Vanished,” Duncan slowed his steps and said, glancing back.

The Nameless One’s dream had once again appeared in the Mortal Realm, and this time Duncan meant to test many of his ideas. The “enhanced temporary marks” he had left on Vanna, Morris, and the others were only one of those plans, meant simply to strengthen the link between him and his followers. What he cared about more was whether the Vanished that sailed in darkness and fog would appear again.

No matter how the Nameless One’s dream grew next, Duncan had to find a way around its “self?protection mechanism” so he could intervene further in this vast dream. His instincts told him that the eerie Vanished sailing in the mist was his best chance to break through that self?protection.

Because the enchanted sea chart on that ship showed that it was very likely sailing right above the forest of the Nameless One’s dream.

Under the chaotic night sky woven together by sunlight and the World’s Wound, the streets of the city?state were as eerily silent as last time. Duncan and the two dolls left the witch’s now?silent mansion and stepped into the veil of night, where city and forest intertwined.

As he stepped into the veil of night, Duncan also began to carefully reach out to the temporary marks that were now on the “other side” of the dream, trying to call his followers.

This time, he had to be very careful and learn from what had happened last time in that dark, fog?filled space. He had to use the Power of Flame with caution, so he would not… wake Atlantis in the depths of the dream.

…

Strange dark?red rifts covered the sky. Twisted, hazy clouds spread along the edge of the ominous red glow. Under that light, everywhere the eye could see was endless yellow sand and huge rocks.

Rolling dunes filled the view. Jagged rocks stood under the sky like the twisted, struggling bones of countless giant beasts. Yellow sand buried their bases. Their sharp edges rose like blades. In this vast, hopeless sea of sand, a “person” looked smaller than ever.

Vanna lifted her head. The wind lifted her long silver?white hair. The dry wind, filled with sand, swept over the land without rest and made her narrow her eyes.

She had come again to this desert, this boundless, dead and withered land.

Looking at the hazy silhouettes of huge rocks in the distance, Vanna let out a small breath and reached into the wind. Misty water vapor gathered out of the dry sandstorm in a way that defied common sense and condensed in her hand into a greatsword that radiated cold.

Feeling the heavy weight of the greatsword in her hand, Vanna nodded in satisfaction.

This boundless desert in the dream was dry and scorching, not a pleasant place at all for a believer of the storm Goddess. Luckily, her power as the Saint of the Deep Sea Church still worked here. The dream could not block power granted by a god. That would at least make her trek here a little easier.

Drawing coolness from the greatsword, Vanna stepped into the sandstorm and walked in a chosen direction.

She was not walking aimlessly, of course. Her goal was that rugged band of shadows in the distance, those shapes that looked like jagged rocks but also like the ruins of a city.

As she walked, Vanna suddenly felt a stir in her heart.

She stopped without thinking and focused, performing the Listening rite toward a voice that had suddenly appeared deep in her mind. A moment later, the voice grew clear—it was the Captain.

The Captain's calm, steady voice echoed in her mind: "Vanna, can you hear me?"

"I can," Vanna answered at once in her heart, and without noticing it she let out a breath of relief inside. "Great. It looks like your plan worked."

"Yes, just as expected," Duncan's voice continued. "I have to be careful when I contact you now. I can't pass too much power at once. From what we learned last time, Atlantis, sleeping deep in the Nameless One's dream, doesn't seem to like my flames."

"I understand," Vanna said, starting forward again as she answered. "How are the others?"

"The others are scattered in the depths of that forest. Their groups are basically the same as last time. Shirley is with Dog, Nina is with Morris," Duncan told Vanna about the others. "Also, after entering Dreamwalking, Lucretia managed to find the rabbit Rabby—they almost 'landed' in the same place."

"Miss Lucretia found that strange rabbit? They landed in the same place? And the others' 'groups' are the same as last time?" Vanna's steps slowed

for a moment, and she grew thoughtful. “It seems… the way we enter this dream really does follow a pattern…”

“Mm. So far it also looks like their positions in the forest are about the same as last time,” Duncan said. Then he asked about Vanna’s side: “What is it like where you are?”

Vanna stopped and lifted her head to look at the endless sand before her.

After a few seconds, this Saint of the storm Goddess let out a sigh.

“Sand, rocks, dry hot weather—the ‘place’ where each of us enters the Nameless One’s dream doesn’t seem to have changed much. I’m still in this desert. Honestly, I don’t like this place…”

Chapter 587: Sand and Forest

According to the original plan, Vanna continued toward the hazy silhouettes in the distance, trekking through the seemingly endless wind and sand.

“…I still don’t know why only I was ‘sent’ to this strange desert. It clearly doesn’t match the ‘forest’ that Nina or Miss Lucretia described. I’m trying to reach that ‘stone circle’ in the distance that looks like a ruined city, and so far I haven’t found any sign of civilization here…”

Duncan’s voice sounded in the depths of Vanna’s mind: “…Pay attention to any phenomenon around you that breaks common sense or to sudden changes in the environment. The kind of ‘corruption’ Shirley mentioned may also appear near you. Be very careful.”

“Understood, Captain,” Vanna nodded slightly, raised her head in the wind to look toward the far horizon, and stepped toward the deeper sands. “I’m going to keep moving.”

…

“Rabby doesn’t like this place… Rabby likes lively places with lots of people… This isn’t the kind of ‘dream’ Rabby is used to. Rabby can’t even see a single person…”

Rabby’s chattering voice came from the side. The huge stuffed rabbit doll stumbled clumsily through bushes and piles of dead leaves and branches, and had been complaining nonstop since just now.

But Lucretia did not pay any attention to the rabbit's grumbling. She simply walked ahead on her own and stopped at the edge of a clearing, carefully observing the surroundings.

Since entering this "dream" for the second time, she had not seen the elf maiden who called herself "Celine," nor had she found any trace of the marks she had left in the forest before.

Everywhere were towering trees that all looked more or less the same. There were no landmarks or paths she could use as a guide. Although she did not want to admit it… Lucretia knew that she was already lost in this vast jungle.

"…Rabby," Lucretia suddenly turned her head and looked at the stuffed rabbit doll that was struggling out of a bush not far away. "Can you sense any other mental entities?"

Rabby stopped its endless complaining at once and hurried over to its Mistress with a few quick steps, posing as if it were listening carefully to the surroundings. The two long ears sewn from cloth strips drooped on either side of its head, and the edges of the cloth quietly took on a hazy look.

A moment later, the rabbit shook its head: "No. Rabby didn't hear any other thinking."

"Mm." Lucretia nodded, then looked around again, trying to decide which way to go next.

Just then, a flash of reflected light in her field of view caught this "witch's" eye.

Lucretia immediately looked toward where the glint had appeared. It was at the foot of a towering tree a dozen meters away. Something seemed to lie among the fallen branches and leaves under the tree.

Her figure suddenly turned into a swirl of colorful paper scraps that flew to the base of the tree in the blink of an eye and then gathered back into her form.

Looking at the slightly familiar thing before her, Lucretia widened her eyes a little: “This is…”

A long?handled weapon, strangely shaped like a mix of spear and battle? axe, was lying quietly among the fallen leaves like a silent, frozen symbol.

Unlike what she remembered, the weapon’s long haft was now broken, as if it had been completely destroyed by a powerful impact. Jagged scars covered the axe blade, as if it had gone through a long and brutal battle. Many dark stains still clung to the chipped edge.

It seemed to have broken a very long time ago, after a fierce fight that people had already forgotten.

Lucretia quietly turned her gaze on the broken poleaxe lying on the ground. No one knew how many thoughts were hidden in her steady stare. Rabby’s footsteps came from behind. After peeking around and looking her Mistress up and down, the stuffed rabbit finally could not hold back its curiosity and asked: “Mistress, what is this thing?”

Lucretia did not answer Rabby. She only bent down cautiously and, after a brief hesitation, reached out toward the broken poleaxe.

When her fingers touched the cold metal, a sensation that seemed to cross illusion and the Mortal Realm rushed along her fingertips. Before she could examine that fleeting feeling, a sharp, howling noise suddenly cut her motion short!

In the next second, the shrill howl came from all directions. A thunderous roar rushed in as if the whole forest were burning and collapsing in explosions. The ground shook. Heat waves surged up. The sky was covered

by chaotic phantom light. Countless shouts, screams, roars, and cries of rage that seemed to come from the forest itself all poured into Lucretia's senses at once— The "sea witch" snapped her head up and saw that the entire forest around her had already begun to burn. The towering trees melted and toppled in the flames. In the distance, the land rose as if some vast invisible force were rolling it upward. With terrifying cracks and surging magma, the whole ground was slowly curling toward the sky. At the same time, huge shadows and chaotic lights beyond human understanding pressed down from above again and again, as if the entire sky were burning with light and falling on the world.

In this mind?shaking "falling sky," a dark?red light appeared. It looked like a wound soaked in blood. Ominous red radiance spread through the clouds and almost instantly replaced all other light. Terrifying cracks began to touch the ground bit by bit, touching the towering trees, touching the curling, upturned horizon in the distance. With each deadly "touch," the world slowly split apart. Countless dark and horrifying things swarmed out — They poured out of the forest, out of the red light in the sky, out of the cracks in the world. One second they still seemed to be animals fleeing in terror from the forest fire. The next second they turned into clawing, nameless shadows. Rocks came alive. The forest writhed. Everything was turning into shapes beyond human understanding. Horrible, twisted things charged in from every side. Someone roared nearby as if fighting desperately against the swarming monsters. But when she followed the sound, all she could see were monsters tearing at monsters and shadows devouring shadows.

Lucretia sprang to her feet. Even though the incomprehensible cataclysm before her left her at a loss for a moment, she still slipped instinctively into a fighting stance—yet in the very next second, all those horrible distortions vanished from her sight.

She had let go of the broken poleaxe. As the contact broke, all the terrifying visions of change disappeared like phantoms.

The forest returned to its original state. Everything that had just happened felt like a short, strange nightmare.

Lucretia stood there stunned for a long moment. After several seconds, she suddenly snapped back to herself and looked down at the foot of the giant tree on instinct.

The broken poleaxe was gone. Only a pile of fallen branches and leaves remained, with no trace of anything else.

Lucretia slowly furrowed her brow, still replaying what she had just seen in her mind. At that moment, the sound of footsteps suddenly appeared nearby and instantly broke her thoughts.

She immediately lifted her head and looked toward the source of the footsteps.

The elf maiden called “Celine” was standing there before she knew it. She still wore that light armor of some unknown city?state’s style and held that oddly shaped long?handled battle?axe in her hand.

Lucretia turned her head sharply toward the rabbit Rabby, only to see Rabby also turning to look at her. Even with only button eyes and a roughly painted mouth, its movements still showed clear apology and surprise—Rabby had not sensed Celine approaching at all. That meant this mental entity had appeared nearby all at once.

“Celine?” Lucretia steadied herself. She signaled for Rabby not to move around and turned to the elf maiden, testing a greeting.

Celine, the elf maiden, showed a slight smile. She looked at Lucretia with an expression that made it seem as if they had never been apart.

She nodded and said: “We’ve been resting for a long time. It’s time to get back on the road—the Wall of Silence is still very far from here.”

As she spoke, she glanced at the rabbit Rabby, who was standing very obediently where it was.

Not a hint of anything strange showed on Celine’s face. She said to Lucretia in a very natural tone: “Is she your friend? Bring her along. We’ll go together.”

…

Vanna did not know how long she had been trekking through this endless desert. The monotonous, boundless landscape and the never?ending wind and sand around her seemed to disturb her sense of time. She even felt as if she had been walking here for a century, as if she had been trudging through this desert since the day the world was born.

Of course, she knew very well that this was only an illusion born of her irritation, a test of her mind set by this harsh place.

Fortunately, her prayers to the Goddess still worked. They kept her faith firm. Her link with the Captain eased the unease in her heart and gave her a chance to steady her mood.

The icy greatsword in her hand gave off thin threads of chill. It brought a sense of safety and also eased the desert’s burning heat.

Another wave of wind and sand struck. Vanna sensed the change in the wind’s direction. She raised the greatsword in front of her and turned her head to shield herself from the blowing grit.

But just then, a strange aura suddenly appeared in her senses and made Vanna freeze in mid?motion.

In the next second, this battle?hardened inquisitor tensed every muscle. She swung the greatsword out to her side in a guarding stance and looked toward a certain point in the blowing sand.

The chaotic wind had stopped at some point. As the dust slowly settled, an unusually tall figure emerged from the haze and grew clearer and clearer.

It was… a giant.

Chapter 588: giants

Vanna tensed her muscles and nerves at once, watching the tall figure that slowly emerged from the dusty haze with full alert. If anything looked even a little wrong, she was ready to leap forward and chop down at him.

But from within the wind and dust came only a calm and reasonable voice: “Ah… a traveler. I don’t think I’ve seen a stranger appear here for many years.”

Vanna froze for a moment. Then she saw that giant-like figure walk out of the dust.

He stood at least four or five meters tall, so tall that Vanna had to tilt her head back as far as she could just to see the giant’s face. A dark, ragged robe wrapped around his body. It seemed that the robe had once been a fine, splendid garment, but now it was nothing but worn, tattered cloth that had endured countless years. The giant’s body was thin and gaunt, as if a long journey had worn him down to almost bare bones—yet that skinny hand still gripped a staff so huge it almost looked ridiculous.

Even in the giant’s hand, the long staff looked far too heavy and massive. Its shaft was like a straight tree trunk with jointed segments, and the top of the staff swelled like a bloated stone, its outline rough and barely carved. On the surface of the staff, Vanna could see countless dense, complicated, mysterious markings, covering the entire Gatekeeper’s cane.

Vanna’s gaze was drawn to the Gatekeeper’s cane against her will. It did not look like a tool meant to help with travel. It looked more like an astonishing

weapon, or some ritual object with a heavy symbolic meaning. This made her feel, instinctively… a pressure that was almost reverence.

But soon, her attention left the Gatekeeper's cane and returned to the giant.

The giant bent down slightly toward her, and that weathered face turned a gentle divine gaze in her direction. The giant's face did not look like that of humans. He also had clear features, but the lines of those features were too hard and sharp, like stone that had been carved. His eyes shone with a murky brownish yellow, and it seemed as if flames flickered deep inside his eyeballs. Every glance seemed to bring crushing pressure.

"Traveler, where did you come from?" the giant asked.

When he spoke, even the wind and sand around them seemed stirred by an invisible force. Turbulent air currents swirled around Vanna, yet not a single grain of sand or dust landed on her.

Vanna forced herself to control her heartbeat and her expression. In the depths of her mind, she quickly reported this shocking situation to the captain, while she also chose her words and thought carefully before she answered the giant: "I come from outside this desert, very far from here. I don't even know why I ended up in this place. May I ask… who are you?"

"Oh, outside the desert… Now this place has become a desert," the giant said slowly, nodding his head. He did not answer Vanna's question. Instead, his tone carried a sigh. "You are… very interesting, traveler. You're not quite the same as the humans in my memory, but I'm not sure if I remember wrongly—after all, it has been a very, very long time since I last saw a stranger."

Not quite the same as the humans in his memory?

Vanna's heart gave a sudden jolt when she heard this. Right after that, she thought of the way she was "different" compared with an ordinary person.

Had this mysterious giant seen that she had once received a Subspace divine blessing and been “brought back to life”?

But before she could think it through, the giant spoke again: “Traveler, you said you came from far away. How far? Did you cross space, or time?”

Vanna was stunned for a moment.

What did that question… even mean?!

She stared up at the giant’s murky, burning eyes in shock. “I… don’t really understand what you mean.”

“…Then just pretend you didn’t hear it, traveler. Maybe the starting point of a journey no longer matters. The end doesn’t matter either,” the giant said, shaking his head. But then he suddenly seemed to notice something, and looked at Vanna with curiosity. “Are you talking with someone else?”

Vanna, who had been reporting to the captain in the depths of her mind, stopped at once. Although she controlled the expression on her face right away, she knew that the change in her eyes might not have escaped the giant’s notice.

Yet the giant sounded as if he had only asked casually, and did not seem to truly care. He shook his head. “It’s fine if you don’t want to say. Everyone has their own secrets.”

Vanna steadied herself, kept control of every change in her expression, and watched the mysterious giant’s every move. At the same time, she carefully asked again: “Who are you?”

“You’re asking for my name? Let me think…” This time, the giant finally answered her question. But after a brief moment of thought, the giant shook his head. “It’s been too long. I don’t remember… It really has been too long.”

He lowered his gaze to look at Vanna. Wrinkles, like carved lines, slowly gathered on his thin face. “You know, traveler, when there are no other voices left in the whole world, a ‘name’ becomes a meaningless idea. No one else needs to remember you, and you don’t need to introduce yourself to anyone. You slowly forget it, just like you are slowly forgotten by the world…”

He paused, as if he had suddenly fallen into some old memory. Only after a long time did he snap out of it, his voice low: “But besides my name, I do remember a few other things, if you think they matter… Long, long ago, they said I was this world’s deity. Back then, this place was not like this.”

The chaotic wind slowly faded. The drifting dust in the air also settled at some unknown moment. In this boundless sea of sand, the giant and the lost traveler stared at each other.

He had said he once was a deity.

Vanna’s eyes widened. Among all her guesses about the identity of this mysterious giant, none had included this “answer.” For a moment, she did not know how to react. Then she felt a kind of absurd contradiction.

As a follower of the storm goddess Gamona, as the Saint of the Deep Sea Church, one of the four churches of the True Gods, she had run into a giant who claimed to be a deity, deep inside the layered dream of the Nameless One. In theory… she should rise up to fight at once and destroy this self-proclaimed god, fulfilling her duty as an Inquisitor.

But Vanna was no longer the reckless person who had once dared to leap and chop at Captain Duncan the first time she saw him. On the Vanished, she had learned to face unbelievable things with a more rational attitude.

“You are a deity?” Vanna stayed tense as she asked carefully, “Who are the ‘they’ you mentioned? And what exactly is this place?”

“They once lived here,” the giant said, seemingly unaware of Vanna’s sudden wariness. He simply lifted a hand and pointed with his staff toward the endless sea of sand. “But that seems to have been a very, very long time ago… Or maybe it hasn’t been that long?”

The giant stopped, looking a bit puzzled. He stared at the staff in his hand and only after a while did he slowly shake his head. “Time… turned into something I didn’t recognize. In one instant it was stretched out to nearly infinite, and then it was squeezed back again. I can no longer tell when it all happened. I only remember that this used to be the most prosperous heart of the kingdom. The yellow sand under your feet used to be forests and rich soil stretching for thousands of miles. Huge canals crossed the fields, bringing rivers from the plateau over the hills. I watched them build pure white cities here. High walls linked the mountains, and tall towers rose straight out of the jungle. Bright fire lit up the night sky… I remember it was very beautiful.”

The giant spoke slowly. It seemed that he had not talked with anyone for too long and was no longer used to organizing his words as he spoke, so his sentences sounded a bit jumbled, like muttering in a dream. Vanna could only do her best to keep up with his story, to understand and guess at the information hidden in his words, and to imagine how this desert had once looked in some distant past.

Then the giant suddenly stopped again. He lowered his head to look at Vanna and asked curiously: “And what about you? Traveler, who are you? Do you have a name?”

Vanna pressed her lips together without thinking. She held back her first impulse to answer.

She could not recklessly reveal her name to an unknown being—especially when that being called himself a “deity” and was very likely a powerful

higher extraordinary.

Maybe the giant had no ill will, but an extraordinary being strong enough could affect a mortal's fate without any deliberate malice at all. Since becoming the captain's follower, Vanna understood this more deeply than ever.

After a brief moment of hesitation, she answered carefully: "My name is Vanessa. I don't have any special status. I'm just someone who accidentally lost her way and ended up here."

"Vanessa…" the giant murmured softly, then shook his head. "That's not your name."

Vanna felt her heart suddenly race.

But the giant waved his hand right after: "But it doesn't matter. Like I said, everyone has secrets. If you're not willing to reveal your name, then I'll just keep calling you 'traveler'—there is no one else here anyway, so we won't mistake each other."

Vanna was silent for a moment. After that brief awkwardness, she nodded.

"Traveler," the giant went on, "where are you going?"

Vanna hesitated, then looked up at the distant silhouettes that looked like the ruins of a city.

"Let's go together," the giant said, noticing where she was looking. He made a friendly offer. "I don't remember those distant things very well anymore, but we can walk together for a while. I still have some impression of this world."

Vanna did not answer at once, as if she were waiting for something.

A moment later, the captain's order came from the depths of her mind—

“Accept his invitation.”

“All right,” Vanna nodded and looked up at the giant who claimed to be a deity. “It’s an honor to travel with you.”

Chapter 589: Meeting in the Shadows

In the chaotic veil of night woven together from sunlight and the World's Wound, Duncan and his group moved quickly through the silent, empty streets. At last, they stopped at a junction where huge, lush plants had completely covered and blocked the road.

Towering trees blocked out the sky. Thick, twisted vines wrapped around the tall buildings lining the street. Roots rose from the pavement, crawling along the ground like swollen veins. The whole district was deathly still, yet from the dark forested depths there sometimes came faint bird calls or the sound of wind, so vague they felt half real, half illusion. Those airy voices seemed to cross the border between dreams and the Mortal Realm.

"…It really is still here."

Standing at the end of the street, Duncan looked with a serious expression at the massive vine that stretched out of the darkness. He spoke almost to himself.

Alice craned her neck, staring at the long ramp where the vine had grown and spread. She watched it for a long time before she spoke, sounding a bit unsure: "Captain, does this thing look… bigger than last time? I remember it hadn't stretched this far before…"

"You remember right," Duncan exhaled and said in a grave tone, "it's larger than it was. This vine… is growing."

Alice blinked for a while, then let out a soft sigh: “Wow…”

Duncan did not say anything more. Before taking any further action, he checked on the state of Morris and the others in the depths of his mind—especially Vanna’s situation.

Aside from himself and the two dolls, everyone had reached the other side of the Nameless One’s dream, just like last time, and each person’s landing point in the dream had not changed much either. In this, the Nameless One’s dream showed a strange sort of… “continuity” that caught his attention.

Of all of them, Vanna’s situation was the most puzzling.

The Inquisitor miss had once again arrived in that barren desert. And this time, she had run into a giant there who claimed to be a “deity.”

Now Vanna was crossing the endless sea of sand together with that giant. From the information Duncan had received so far, the giant seemed very friendly and had told Vanna many things about the desert.

But what the giant said did not match any of the old legends Duncan knew, or any ancient stories known in this world!

What exactly was that desert? What was the origin of that giant who called himself a deity? How did those lost years he spoke of connect to the ancient heritage of the elves? And why had such a strange place appeared in the depths of the Nameless One’s dream?

Duncan only felt more and more confused.

Right now, all he could do was hope that Vanna could get more information from that boundless sea of sand and from the mysterious giant—or that the others might find some clue in the endless forest that connected to the “desert.”

Keeping the link between his mind and the others, Duncan took a deep breath and brought his attention back to what was in front of him.

The massive vine had once again appeared in the world of the Mortal Realm. For him, this was actually good news—he had worried that the "fright" he gave the Nameless One's dream last time might cause some unpredictable change and make the vine disappear or move somewhere else. If that had happened, it would have been hard for him to keep investigating. But now… at least this thread had not broken.

Of course, the current situation also forced him to worry about something else:

The vine had not disappeared—but it had grown larger instead.

Would this thing keep growing until it wrapped around the whole city?

With that sudden, baseless worry in his mind, Duncan steadied himself, then stepped forward and slowly placed his hand on the end of the vine.

"Watch the surroundings. If anything big changes, wake me up at once," he said over his shoulder to the two dolls behind him.

"Got it!" Alice nodded right away.

Lunie also bent slightly at the waist and answered respectfully: "Yes, Old Master."

Duncan gave a small nod. Then he calmed his thoughts and carefully guided the power of flame, letting his senses spread and seep along thin streams of spirit-form fire, once again building a connection with the vine.

Because of his experience last time, he was even more cautious now, so he would not startle "Atlantis" again like before.

A moment later, Duncan opened his eyes in the darkness.

Endless mist once again filled his sight.

Following his intuition, Duncan looked toward the deepest part of the fog.

A huge, hazy shadow gradually appeared under his divine gaze. Boundless mist drifted and shifted, and the light and shadow within it outlined a familiar silhouette—the Vanished. That awe-inspiring ship floated in the void like a silent ghost, as if… it were wordlessly inviting Duncan aboard.

Duncan gladly accepted the invitation.

In the darkness, he condensed his spirit form into an avatar form. Then, while carefully controlling the flow of the flames around him, he flew toward the Vanished in the depths of the mist and landed silently on its deck.

Just like the last time he saw it, the ship was still empty. Wisps of mist floated over the silent deck. Familiar fittings of the vessel loomed in and out of sight in the fog.

This time, Duncan did not go straight to the captain’s cabin at the stern. After looking around, he stepped in another direction.

He walked through the mist curling over the deck, his footsteps echoing in the empty, deathly still place. He passed piles of coiled ropes and clutter on the planks, heading toward the entrance to the cabins.

The ropes and various items piled on the deck showed no reaction to Duncan’s approach—they simply lay there quietly like ordinary dead objects.

So Duncan noticed another difference between this eerie Vanished and the Vanished he was familiar with.

On the “real” Vanished, all these things on the deck would start moving when he came close. They would greet their captain eagerly or make all

kinds of strange noises, trying to get his attention. But here… though the two ships were almost the same in every detail, everything on this ship was “dead.”

Frowning slightly, Duncan let his eyes sweep over the silent ropes, buckets, and iron hooks. He walked between them, then suddenly stopped.

His gaze had fallen on a mop leaning against the wall.

A moment later, he realized why that sudden feeling of “familiarity” had appeared. Alice had left that mop here when she came back to the ship earlier!

This eerie version of the Vanished not only looked exactly like the “real one” in the Mortal Realm, but it also matched the changes on the Vanished in the Mortal Realm in real time?

Many guesses suddenly rose in his mind. Duncan felt as though he had vaguely grasped some “essence” of this strange Vanished. At that moment, a faint sound from some corner caught his attention at once.

On this ghost ship where everything was so quiet, that tiny sound, like a whisper, stood out sharply.

Duncan instantly locked onto the direction it came from and walked toward it.

He stopped in front of a window.

On the glass, there was a blurry mass that looked like shadows or thick fog mixed with black smoke, slowly forming on the surface as if it were trying to take shape.

Duncan stared at that clump of gathering and scattering shadows for a few seconds, then suddenly realized what it was and spoke softly: “Agatha?”

As soon as he spoke, the shifting shadow on the glass quickly gathered and, within a few seconds, turned into a clear image—Agatha's figure appeared in the window.

"Ah, you finally noticed me," Agatha let out a long breath as soon as she formed on the glass. "I've been calling from the seams between the shadows, trying to get your attention, but it was really hard to find a proper mirror nearby…"

"How are you here?" Duncan looked at the figure in the glass in surprise. Then something occurred to him. "Wait, did you come through the Vanished's…"

"Yes. After nightfall, I stayed in the Vanished's reflection. It might sound risky, but I did it," Agatha said with a nod. "As the reflection shifted, I came here and met up with you. It seems my guess was right: when the veil of night descends, the Vanished's missing 'shadow' turns into this 'other Vanished' you see here. We still don't know the principle behind it, but we finally found a link between the two Vanisheds."

Duncan's brows drew tighter as he listened. He stayed silent, which made Agatha a bit uneasy. "…Did I act on my own when I shouldn't have?"

"You really should have talked with me first, but that's not what I'm thinking about now," Duncan said, waving a hand. "You stayed on the 'reflection' side, so did you see how this transformation happened? Did the Vanished show any clear… 'signs' at the time?"

Agatha shook her head. "There was no process."

"No process?"

"Everything changed in an instant, with no process at all," Agatha repeated. "One second, I was still in the Vanished's reflection, watching and waiting for any possible change in the mirror world world. In the next instant, the

‘atmosphere’ in the mirror world world changed. I could feel it… the Vanished’s shadow turned into something I didn’t recognize. My mirror-leaping was suppressed. I could no longer sense the boundary between the Spirit Realm and the Mortal Realm, and I couldn’t return to the normal mirrors in the Mortal Realm. It was like… the whole world had become strangely thick and sticky, and it was slowly solidifying…”

Duncan listened closely to Agatha’s description, then slowly turned his head and looked toward the stern deck.

That was where the captain’s cabin stood, and where the “other Goathead” stayed.

“Can you move freely now?” Duncan asked suddenly.

“It seems that I’m no longer affected,” Agatha said at once, with a hint of disbelief in her tone. “After you noticed me, that strange pressure vanished all of a sudden.”

“Good,” Duncan nodded. “Then come along—we’re going to visit that ‘First Mate’ whose state is not quite right.”

Chapter 590: Long Since dead

When Duncan opened the captain's cabin door, the Goathead placed at the edge of the chart table reacted at once. It seemed to raise its head in a half-asleep daze, slowly turning toward the doorway, then it recognized the figure standing there.

"Ah, we meet again," the pitch-black wooden carving spoke. Its voice carried a strange slowness, completely different from the usually noisy Goathead who would rattle on at high speed once it started. "You left in such a hurry before…"

"You still remember me?" Duncan asked as he closed the cabin door behind him and walked toward the chart table.

He walked past the old oval mirror near the door. Dim, hazy light stirred on the mirror's surface, and Agatha's faint, translucent figure flashed across the glass.

The Goathead on the table seemed not to notice Agatha at all. Its gaze stayed fixed on Duncan, the head slowly turning with his steps. As it turned, it spoke in that slow voice: "I still remember you. Ah, it really is a little incredible. I have forgotten many things, after all. The feeling of clearly remembering one person… how strange."

Duncan came up to the chart table and glanced down at the enchanted sea chart lying there.

The enchanted sea chart still showed that lush forest projection. The ghostly silhouette that represented the Vanished floated above the treetops, drifting

slowly through the clouds as if it was patrolling the whole forest.

He quickly compared it with the picture in his memory and made sure the sea of trees had not changed much since last time. Only the Vanished had shifted its position by a large distance.

“I did leave in a hurry last time,” Duncan nodded and said as he sat down beside the chart table. His gaze slid over the Oval Scrying Mirror not far away, then fell on Goathead. “How is Atlantis?”

“She is sleeping very soundly now,” Goathead said slowly. “Last time… she was only startled. I hope that did not cause you any trouble.”

“It’s fine. I don’t mind,” Duncan said. He set his hand on the table again and quietly, carefully stirred the Power of Flame.

At the edge of his vision, wisps of eerie green flame appeared in the captain’s cabin.

Duncan quickly held back the spread of the flames, suppressing them in their current state so they would not again disturb the “Atlantis” Goathead had mentioned. At the same time, he finally confirmed something in his heart.

These flames were not ones he had just summoned. They were Fire Seeds he had deliberately left on the Vanished in the Mortal Realm during the day.

The situation was just as he had expected. The Fire Seeds he had left on the Vanished in the Mortal Realm could “burn through” the border between dream and Mortal Realm and appear at the same time on this eerie Vanished. Flames sent over in this way were like stowaways on the dream level. As long as he kept their spread under control, they would not overstimulate Atlantis.

In a sense, the flames projected here like this became part of the “inherent structure” of this eerie Vanished, instead of being treated as foreign objects

that disturbed the dream, like the flames he had summoned here last time.

Duncan let out a soft breath and gave the flames an order. He told them to fade and lie dormant. They withdrew again into the cracks between the deck, the walls, and the ceiling.

He had found a safe way to send fire into this place. If he repeated it once or twice more, he might be able to use these “stowaway” flames to burn through this eerie Vanished and completely seize control of this ship that had formed from the warped shadow of the Vanished.

Goathead showed no reaction at all to Duncan’s actions. To it, the flames that had quietly appeared in the room might as well not exist. It only stayed there quietly, and as long as Duncan did not talk to it, it seemed to be just a lifeless wooden carving.

“Has Atlantis been dreaming all this time?” Duncan asked. As he spoke, he sensed the slow wandering of the Fire Seeds on the ship, and he started to chat with Goathead as if they were making small talk. “That whole forest outside—does it all belong to Atlantis’s dream?”

“Outside?” Goathead shook its head slowly. “I do not know what you mean by ‘outside’, but Atlantis has indeed been dreaming all this time. She… has been dreaming for a very, very long time. In that dream there is a lush forest, and there are… them.”

Duncan’s heart moved at once: “Who are they?”

Goathead lowered its head a little, as if it was about to sink back into a half-asleep state again. But after a moment, it still gave an answer: “They are living beings born in the forest. A very, very long time ago, they gave their race a name. They called themselves elves…”

Duncan’s eyes narrowed at once.

The answer itself did not surprise him much. But in that moment, what came to his mind was the sentence Goathead had said when they spoke on the Vanished in the Mortal Realm—“Remember them”!

The “they” mentioned by the two Goatheads should mean the same group!

Remember them… Why did it have to stress “remember” so much? And in the end, Goathead still forgot “them”… What caused this “forgetting”?

Duncan’s expression shifted several times. As the clues quickly connected in his mind, he felt he was almost certain of his bold guess about Goathead’s true identity. His face grew serious. With special care, he fixed his gaze on Goathead’s eyes.

“What is your name?” he asked.

Goathead did not answer. It only gave a string of vague, groaning sounds, like someone talking in their sleep.

“Are you Saslokar?” Duncan did not mind the lack of answer and kept asking. Without noticing it, he leaned forward a little. “The creator in elf legends, the maker of the first dream, Atlantis’s Creator and guardian god—your name, is it Saslokar?”

Goathead’s unclear muttering stopped at once.

Its head swayed from side to side, as if it had reacted to the name Duncan mentioned. After a few seconds of hesitation and thought, it finally lifted its head slowly.

“Saslokar died. He died a very, very long time ago.”

…

“They died a very, very long time ago. When the world died, no living being could live past that day.”

Never-ending wind and sand rolled over the entire sea of dunes again and again, like the turning of fate. The giant in a tattered robe sat down cross-legged among a heap of twisted, grim rocks. His huge body seemed to intimidate the sand, making the wild wind stop several meters away from the stones so that no dust fell on the traveler.

He was still talking about the things of the past.

Vanna sat across from the giant, resting for a short while as a very good listener.

The stretch of rolling “shadows” that looked like the ruins of a city was already close to them now. They only had to lift their heads to see it.

The journey had been shortened. Vanna could clearly feel that.

At a normal walking speed, she and the giant could not possibly have reached these ruins in such a short time.

This strange thing was clearly tied to traveling with the giant. It seemed that as long as she journeyed together with him, the “distance” on the road would shrink.

After thinking of this, Vanna did not hide her guess. She spoke her thoughts out loud.

The giant answered very calmly: “I can reach any corner of this ‘world’ in a single day. This is my ability. Only in this way can I keep watching and recording all the changes that happen in this world. To observe and record —that is my duty.”

As he said this, he shook his head again with a hint of emotion. “But… now there is almost nothing left in this world worth watching or recording.”

Vanna lifted her head and stared at the ruins in the distance, a little lost in thought.

They were indeed ruins of a city, just as she had first guessed. But when she first saw them, she had almost failed to connect that ruin to the idea of a “city”.

It was a stretch of piled gray-black boulders. The jagged, strange blocks of stone spread across the sand-covered ground like a forest of rocks. They no longer showed any trace of once being buildings. You could hardly see any mark of having been shaped by civilization.

Vanna could not imagine what kind of disaster could turn a grand city into this. It looked as if the entire city had melted in an instant. More than half of the material in the city had turned to gas in the blink of an eye. The remaining structures had melted and flowed, then solidified again under a sudden, violent drop in temperature, becoming these jagged blocks of stone.

But if it really had been some moment of extreme heat… why was the wide land outside the city just a sea of sand?

That kind of heat should have melted the sand as well, turning it into glass-like material. There should not be any desert around the city at all. It should have become one huge sheet of fused obsidian.

Vanna’s grades in her cultural classes had not been very good, but she still had this basic knowledge.

“What exactly happened to turn the city into this?” she could not help asking the giant. “You just said the world died… What killed this world?”

The giant lowered his head. His furrowed face looked like something carved from stone, and his eyes, which looked as if murky flames burned in them, locked his gaze onto Vanna’s eyes.

“Do not try to understand that Doomsday,” he said. “It is already beyond mortal minds, and even beyond the wisdom of deities. When it came, the people who worshiped me begged me for help. I took one look at

Doomsday, and it burned through my sanity and my soul, traveler… That is not something that can be described with words.”

The giant spoke and slowly raised his hand, pointing at the blood-red crack in the sky.

“The only thing I can tell you is this: when Doomsday came, a corruption that did not belong to this world poured out of that rift. In an instant, it shattered the ground under our feet and forced it to re-form in pain. All our splendor turned to dust in the corruption.”

Chapter 591: Toward the deep layers

“Did you hear something?”

On a natural path deep in the forest, Shirley suddenly stopped walking and muttered, a little suspicious.

“I did not hear anything, but I smelled… that clear ‘stench’,” Dog stopped beside Shirley, a low, disgusted sound rumbling in his throat. “More than one. It is mixed with the foul sense of chaotic, dull minds, and a pure, blind urge to destroy…”

“Looks like those ‘old acquaintances’ really came back,” Shirley grumbled. “They never get tired, do they? What does this ‘Nameless One’s dream’ have that makes them care so much? Is that so-called ‘original Blueprint’ really that attractive?”

Dog did not answer. He only crouched low and carefully felt out the lingering traces in the air—the scent left by Annihilators and Abyssal demons.

In those traces, he found something familiar.

“The Annihilator named ‘Richard’ is among them,” he said suddenly, lifting his head.

“That guy dared to come back?” Shirley stared in surprise. “After I smashed him like that last time, I thought he would have to lie in bed in the Mortal Realm for a while…”

Dog shook his head. “It seems they all made full preparations before dreamwalking. They have strong enough protection on the mental level. The damage they take in the dream will not affect the Mortal Realm too much. That makes sense. After all, if they gathered so many people to enter the Nameless One’s dream, they must already understand how this place works very well.”

Shirley frowned. “Are they still nearby?”

“They left a while ago,” Dog judged carefully. “The scent of the Abyssal demons is fading fast, but it is hard to say how far they are now. Shirley, we have to be careful. That ‘Richard’ is here too. He knows you. Last time’s trick will not work a second time.”

The look on Shirley’s face grew tense at once. She quickly checked the surroundings, then turned and said seriously to Dog: “Then how about we just find a place to hide here? We wait until it is dawn in the Mortal Realm. This forest is huge. Those cultists probably will not double back.”

“I do not suggest that. Do not forget that strange and dangerous ‘corruption’ phenomenon. It happens suddenly and spreads fast,” Dog said, shaking his head. “There is no corner here that is truly safe. The only place that might be safe is inside that so-called Wall of Silence. We need to find that ‘wall’.”

As he spoke, he lifted his head and looked toward a certain direction deeper in the forest. “Those Annihilators are also searching for the Wall of Silence. We can follow behind them from far away. As long as we stay hidden, the initiative will be in our hands.”

“Tch, fine, I was just talking,” Shirley clicked her tongue and said helplessly. “Let’s go then. Just make sure we don’t get too close to those cultists.”

Dog nodded. He checked the lingering scent in the air again and the direction it pointed to, then stepped forward—but he had only taken one step when he suddenly stopped and spoke quickly in a low voice: “Careful, someone is coming!”

Almost as soon as Dog finished speaking, Shirley heard sudden footsteps nearby. There had been no warning at all, as if a person had appeared out of thin air. Shirley’s whole body went rigid. She gripped her chain hard and snapped her head toward the source of the sound.

A tall elf maiden appeared in Shirley’s sight.

She wore a strange style of light armor that looked like hunter’s gear suited for moving through a forest, with extra reinforcement at key points. She had long, pale-gold hair like sunlight, with faintly glowing blue threads woven through it. In her hand was a weapon of odd design, like a mix of a long spear and a long-handled battle-axe.

Seeing this elf maiden who seemed to appear from nowhere, Shirley froze for a second. In that brief moment, the elf maiden had already taken a step toward her.

“You did not receive the evacuation order? Why are you still moving around outside the wall?”

Hearing the woman’s voice, Shirley opened her mouth. The sudden change left her a little lost. But she reacted quickly. All the acting and ability to read people that she had practiced since childhood came to life. “Ah, I… got lost. I was just about to head toward the Wall of Silence.”

The unfamiliar elf maiden did not seem to notice Shirley’s brief panic. She did not show any odd reaction to Dog either, even though Dog, with his fierce and twisted appearance, had not had time to hide. She simply nodded to Shirley and Dog and said: “You and your partner are in an area where

corruption events are active. This place is not safe. Luckily for you, you met me, the ranger."

As she spoke, she pointed with her long-handled axe toward a direction in the forest. "Come with me. I will take you to the Wall of Silence."

"Ah… okay." Shirley froze for a moment, then quickly reacted. At the same time, she called for the captain in the depths of her mind and tugged Dog along to follow.

They set off toward the direction of the Wall of Silence, walking along a natural path covered in fallen branches and leaves, crossing uneven clearings between the trees as they went deeper and deeper into the forest.

The elf maiden with the strange weapon walked in front. She spoke very little along the way.

That was not good for gathering information, so Shirley had to break the silence herself. After thinking for a moment, she asked: "By the way, what is your name?"

The elf maiden suddenly stopped and turned. She looked straight into Shirley's eyes with a very serious expression. Only after two or three seconds did she answer softly: "My name is Celine—I hope you can remember my name."

Shirley's eyes widened.

…

In the vast darkness and fog, on the eerie, silent Vanished, Duncan, who was sitting beside the chart table talking with Goathead, suddenly froze and stopped his conversation with it.

He frowned slightly, as if he was using some kind of Listening rite to catch a sound from far away. His expression shifted quickly, from confusion to

thoughtful focus.

Goathead on the table showed no reaction to Duncan's sudden silence. Once Duncan stopped talking, it simply grew quiet with him. It asked no questions and showed no wish to speak on its own.

The Goathead that appeared on this eerie Vanished was like an "answering machine" stuck in a half-asleep state. Aside from speaking first to greet him, it rarely reacted to anything if Duncan did not speak to it.

Duncan glanced at Goathead.

In the end, this Goathead still had not explained what it meant by "Saslokar died long ago". It only repeated that sentence over and over, as if its thoughts had jammed on that one piece of information.

After a short hesitation, Duncan rose from his chair and walked toward the old oval mirror not far away.

On the chart table, the black Goathead carving creaked as it moved again. Its dark, deep, cloudy eyes followed Duncan's movements without a sound. The silent gaze only made it seem more unnerving.

But Duncan had, more or less, learned to ignore the eerie side of this suspicious Goathead. He walked straight up to the mirror and knocked on the glass.

Agatha's figure appeared on the mirror's surface almost at once.

Duncan paid close attention to the gaze on his back and the changes in the cabin's atmosphere. But the strange Goathead showed no reaction at all to Agatha's appearance, as if it could not see her.

"Captain." In the mirror, Agatha also gave a cautious glance toward Goathead. Only after she was sure it truly did not react did she let out a quiet breath and nod to Duncan.

“Shirley and Dog met another ‘Celine’ in the forest,” Duncan answered Agatha’s greeting, then spoke directly.

Agatha’s lips parted. Her expression looked stunned for a moment, then she reacted at once: “Then Miss Lucretia…”

Duncan nodded. “She is still with ‘Celine’.”

The two of them fell silent on either side of the mirror. It was clear that neither of them had any good ideas.

After a while, Agatha drew a slow breath and broke the silence: “Captain, I have made some discoveries here too.”

Duncan lowered his voice without thinking: “What did you find?”

In the mirror, Agatha lifted her hand and silently pointed at the door at the very back of the captain’s cabin—the wooden door that led to the captain’s bedroom.

“While you were talking with Goathead just now, I passed through all the mirrors on this Vanished,” she said. “Every mirror’s position and the scenes they showed were almost no different from those on the Vanished in the Mortal Realm. Only inside there… I was blocked by a strange ‘barrier’.”

Duncan looked toward the captain’s bedroom at once. As he listened to Agatha’s account, his eyes grew more and more serious.

After thinking for a moment, he walked toward the door.

On the chart table, the black Goathead carving creaked and shifted again. Its dark eyes tracked Duncan’s movements.

Duncan wrapped his hand around the doorknob, but he did not push it open right away. Instead, he turned and stared at Goathead on the table. After a short stare-down, he spoke in a low voice: “What is in there?”

“I do not know,” Goathead said slowly.

“Can I go in?”

“I do not know,” Goathead repeated, as if it were echoing itself.

“…If I go in, what will happen?”

“I do not know.” The suspicious Goathead seemed as if it would only ever repeat that one line.

But at least, it did not seem like it meant to stop him.

Duncan gave Goathead one last, long look. Then he turned back to the familiar cabin door in front of him, took a deep breath, and twisted the handle.

An empty space of tangled, overlapping chaos appeared beyond the door, as if countless abstract lines had been drawn and layered there again and again.

Duncan stood in the doorway and stared at the “room” inside. Among those chaotic, overlapping lines, he could still just make out a few things: a bed, a table, a window, a wall.

But all of them had lost their true form. It was as if they had been torn apart and crudely reassembled inside the mind of someone whose thoughts were broken, then replayed in a twisted dream. There was no way to see what they had originally looked like.

Chapter 592: Stone

After standing for a long time in front of this “room” made entirely of chaotic lines and blocks of color, Duncan turned his head a little and watched Goathead on the table from the corner of his eye.

From Goathead’s point of view, it should now also be able to see the scene inside the room. He wondered how Goathead would react after seeing this bizarre, disordered space.

But it had no reaction. It only kept using those emotionless, pitch-black eyes to calmly gaze in Duncan’s direction. When it made no sound, it was like a real block of wood.

Duncan turned back again. After a brief hesitation, he finally stepped toward the strange room built from tangled lines.

At the same time, he was ready. If anything went wrong, he would force his flames to rise, wake Atlantis, and break out of this “dream”.

But the worst he had imagined did not happen.

He stepped through the door. Faint ripples, clear and thin like water, spread across the entire chaotic room, then faded. Nothing else happened. The room did not collapse, and he himself did not seem affected by the twisted colors and lines.

Duncan walked deeper into the room and, as he passed, closed the door behind him. The unsettling, silent gaze of that strange Goathead on the table was finally blocked outside.

The tangled colored lines stretched out under his feet. Vaguely furniture-like shapes, sketched by those lines, surrounded him on every side. Duncan carefully watched everything in the room, feeling an extremely eerie atmosphere pressing in from all around. After a moment, his gaze finally settled on one corner of the “room”.

Several translucent colored lines trembled there. They linked together into a geometric outline. At the center of that shaking outline lay what looked like a flat, calm water surface that faintly reflected the surroundings.

Duncan walked up to that geometric frame and reached out, gently brushing the calm “water”. Strands of ghostly green flame spread across the surface. A moment later, the scene reflected there became clear—it turned into a mirror.

In the next second, shadows stirred at the center of the mirror, and Agatha’s figure quietly appeared within.

The lady in the mirror stared in shock at the chaotic, eerie place outside the glass.

“This… this is what was behind that door?!”

Duncan nodded slightly: “Yes. This is what is inside the door—the deepest part.”

“This place looks… so strange,” Agatha said, frowning hard. “How can it be like this?”

But Duncan seemed to have already understood a few things. He spoke calmly: “Because on the Vanished in the Mortal Realm, Goathead never dared look into the captain’s cabin. It doesn’t know what this room looks like.”

At least, it didn’t know what the cabin looked like after the “captain” moved in. Duncan did not say that part out loud.

Agatha instantly understood the deeper meaning in his words.

“You mean… this ‘Vanished’ really was ‘created’ by Goathead from the Mortal Realm?” she said quickly. “It turned the Vanished’s shadow into this ship sailing in darkness and fog, but it can’t restore the parts of the ship it doesn’t understand…”

As she spoke, Agatha suddenly frowned and shook her head. “But in the Mortal Realm, Goathead acts like it knows nothing about any of this. And how did it even do all this…”

“Maybe it really does know nothing,” Duncan said quietly, his gaze slowly sweeping the room. “Right now I have a bold guess: this ship might be one of its dreams.”

“Its dream?!” Agatha froze for a second, then seemed to think of something. Confusion appeared on her face. “But it clearly said it never dreams, it never even rests. And I saw it myself—the First Mate is always awake. Even last time, when the Nameless One’s dream appeared, it was still at the helm, just like always.”

“Because it doesn’t know it’s dreaming at all. It doesn’t even know it can dream. It might even…” Duncan stopped for a moment. An even bolder thought rose in his mind. He hesitated a few seconds, then spoke softly, almost to himself: “Maybe our First Mate has never woken up.”

When she realized what the captain’s words meant, Agatha’s eyes slowly widened.

After a brief silence, Duncan spoke again: “Then now there is only one last question left.”

Agatha repeated without thinking: “The last question?”

Duncan lifted his head and looked at the door standing amid the twisted lines. His gaze seemed to pass through the door toward the Goathead sitting

on the table outside. After a long time, he murmured: “Saslokar is dead. Saslokar died a very, very long time ago…”

…

veil of night fell over the desert. It came so suddenly that everything around them dimmed at once. The sourceless glow that had filled the sky vanished in an instant, as if something had swallowed it. Quiet night spread over the sea of sand and the wide ruins buried in it.

Now, only a huge, unsettling dark red “crack” remained in the sky. The crack was like blood, its edges like fog. It covered the heavens and gave off a crushing pressure.

Even someone as strong-willed as Vanna, an Inquisitor, subconsciously avoided looking up at that “wound in the world”.

But the giant traveling with her seemed long used to all of this.

At the edge of the ruined city, they found a spot sheltered from wind and sand. It had once been part of a solemn building, but now only a few melted, twisted dark walls remained. The giant picked up many gray-white stones from the nearby ruins and piled them in a corner out of the wind. Then he took two stones in his hands and patiently struck them together.

The dark, silent desert and the oppressive red wound in the sky seemed to no longer exist for him. In his eyes there were only the stones he was striking. The tap-tap-tap of stone on stone echoed dully through the veil of night and carried very, very far.

Vanna sat under the sheltering wall, watching the giant with curiosity. After a long time, she finally could not help asking: “What are you doing?”

“Drawing fire,” the giant said calmly. “Here, the nights are very cold.”

“But those are just stones…” Vanna looked at the gray-white rocks the giant had gathered, her voice full of doubt. “Are they stones that can burn?”

“They are ordinary stones,” the giant said without turning. “There is nothing else left here. Aside from sand, there are only stones.”

Vanna opened her mouth: “Then…”

She did not finish. A sudden burst of sparks cut her off. Tiny sparks leaped from between the stones in the giant’s hands and fell into the pile of pale rocks on the ground. Then the sparks turned into small flames. Bright fire rose from the stones and slowly grew stronger.

Vanna stared at this scene, unable to understand.

“Fire, and stone. They are the most important things,” the giant said quietly, gazing at the flames burning among the rocks. It sounded as if he were speaking to Vanna, and also to himself. “Flames that are lit are eyes opened in the veil of night. Stones broken by blows are far better than fangs and claws. When they lit branches, when they struck stones against each other, something unimaginable happened…”

The giant turned his head and lowered his eyes: “Traveler, do you know? The history of civilization started with fire and stone.”

Vanna listened, half understanding, and slowly nodded.

She had never done well in her culture classes, but she could still understand what the giant meant. She just did not know why the giant suddenly wanted to tell her this.

What did this have to do with “stones that could catch fire”?

But the giant clearly did not plan to explain further. He soon went back to his “work”. He reached into the pile of stones, not seeming to care about the heat of the flames, and took out a stone that had already been blackened by

fire. He knocked off one corner of it, leaving a sharp point. Then he picked up the huge staff he had set aside earlier and, using the stone's sharp edge, began patiently carving something on the surface.

The staff was very hard, and the stone points were fragile and easy to break. So the giant's carving went very, very slowly. It often took many strokes to leave even a shallow mark on the staff. He also had to stop often and chip the stone again to make new "chisels".

The surface of the huge staff was covered in countless markings… Had all those marks been carved this way?!

Even after watching only a short while, Vanna realized that this was a task so hard and slow it bordered on hopeless. She could not imagine how long the giant had worked, or how much patience he had spent, to leave all those countless marks on that huge Gatekeeper's cane. She felt that even if she had an endless lifespan, she still would not be able to do such a thing!

Yet the giant just carved in silence and patience, using the only tool he could find in this dead world—stones baked by fire.

At last, Vanna could not help breaking the silence: "What are you doing?"

"Recording," the giant said slowly. "Recording the things I still remember. Recording what once happened in this world."

He stopped and put the staff in front of Vanna, then raised a hand and pointed at its lower end. There was a row of tiny symbols there.

"Here, they learned how to use fire."

The giant spoke softly. There was a hint of pride in his tone.

Vanna followed the direction of his finger and finally saw the tiny symbols clearly. Only now did she see their details.

Simple lines formed the outlines of two small human figures. They stood in front of an abstract campfire, arms raised high, as if they were cheering and jumping, or as if they were worshiping the flames.

For some reason, Vanna suddenly felt a heavy weight pressing on her heart. She instinctively let her gaze climb up along the Gatekeeper’s cane, looking at the dense symbols there. She quickly saw that they were not all pictographs. Higher up the cane, the pictographs slowly turned into abstract, unfamiliar writing. The writing slowly changed again into many forms. Some split into letters. Others still kept a picture-like structure…

Her eyes finally rested on a small blank patch at the very top of the Gatekeeper’s cane. The campfire crackled beside her, and its light flickered over that empty space.

Vanna slowly lifted her head. Her gaze traced along the rough chipped stone and the thin arm holding it, and finally landed on the giant’s face.

The face, covered in wrinkles, was quietly watching the fire pit beside them, motionless, like another stone.

Chapter 593: Remnants Gather

On a patch of forest clearing lit by sunlight, Nina and Morris stopped and looked together at the tall figure who seemed to have suddenly appeared out of the air and now stood at the fork in the path with a surprised expression.

“Did you not receive the order to retreat?” After that brief moment of surprise, the elven maiden, dressed in light hunting gear and holding a strange long-handled weapon, spoke. Her voice was as pleasant as a stream in the woods. “Why are you still wandering outside the Wall of Silence?”

Nina and Morris quietly met each other’s eyes, then both gave a tiny nod.

“Uncle Duncan,” Nina said in the back of her mind, “we’ve run into a third ‘Celine’ here… Yes, she also mentioned the Wall of Silence.”

Morris quickly adjusted his expression and nodded to the elven maiden who had suddenly appeared at the edge of the clearing. He asked calmly: “We didn’t receive any message… May I ask what is happening now?”

The elven maiden frowned, seeming a little surprised at Morris’s “ignorance”, but that feeling soon faded from her face. “The situation is very bad. The corruption is spreading outside the Wall of Silence. Right now, only inside the Wall of Silence is safe in the whole realm—we still haven’t found the Creator. All elves must return to the inside of the Wall of Silence at once, to receive Atlantis’s protection.”

They still hadn’t found the Creator?!

Morris instantly caught that line, which held so much information. But he quickly controlled his expression, nodding seriously. “Then can you take us to the ‘Wall of Silence’?”

“Of course. Meeting a ‘ranger’ like me is your luck,” the elven maiden replied at once, nodding. “I may be among the last rangers still patrolling outside the wall—follow me, while the signs of corruption haven’t shown here yet.”

She turned and walked toward the depths of the forest, but after only a few steps she suddenly stopped and glanced back. “By the way, my name is Celine… Please remember this name.”

Morris and Nina quickly traded a look, then nodded in unison.

The elven maiden called Celine turned back around and kept leading her two uninvited guests into the depths of the forest, toward the Wall of Silence she kept mentioning.

…

After trekking through the forest for who knew how long, Shirley even started to doubt one thing: did this place called the Wall of Silence really exist?

She could no longer remember how long she had been following the elf ahead, or how far she had moved through this sea of trees. In her eyes, the forest looked the same everywhere—nothing but trees and more trees. Now and then she saw a fallen trunk lying in the dead leaves, or rocks and streams blocking the path. That already counted as rare “scenery” on the road.

The scenery was dull, and the road was even worse. The forest floor, covered in rotting leaves, was soft and uneven. Vines, thorns, and roots that stuck up from the ground kept appearing and were easy to trip over. She had

once thought that the narrow, bumpy alleys of the lower city shantytown, cut to pieces by steam and gas pipes, were already the hardest roads in the world to walk. Now she found that for humans, even the most run-down corners of a town were far friendlier than this pure “nature”.

[What was it the captain said again… something called “the shaping power of civilization”?]

Shirley let her thoughts wander in her head, and, like a sacred miracle, she even recalled things she had learned in class. Then she lifted her head again and looked at the elf guiding them.

Celine, on the other hand, kept walking as if she were flying. This rough, hard forest seemed like a part of her own body. She moved through the annoying trees and vines as freely as wind blowing through a courtyard.

At last, Shirley stopped.

Celine stopped at once as well. The elven maiden did not even turn around, but it was as if she sensed the moment Shirley stopped walking.

“How far is it from here to the Wall of Silence?” Shirley asked first, before the other could speak.

“Very far. The Wall of Silence is very far away,” Celine answered with a serious face, though her answer was no answer at all. “We cannot rest for long. We must return to Atlantis’s protection as soon as possible, we must… get there before the corruption catches up.”

“What exactly is this ‘corruption’?” Shirley thought for a moment and finally asked the question that had made her curious the whole way.

She had not asked before because she was afraid that such a “basic” question might upset the elven maiden in front of her. According to Miss Lucretia, “Celine” was a “native mind” that moved inside a dream. Shirley did not really understand what a native mind was, but she roughly knew it

was something very tricky. If you carelessly mentioned knowledge beyond its “boundary”, spoke of things outside the dream, or even just asked a few too many questions, it might cause that mind to go wrong.

Shirley was no stranger to “going wrong” like that. When she made up lessons with Alice and heard things that went beyond what she could understand, she would go wrong too—the main symptom was her thoughts cutting out.

In her own way, she understood the idea Miss Lucretia had explained. She believed that if she asked questions she should not ask, she could also make this elf maiden named Celine blank out.

She had been trying her best to avoid that.

But after spending some time with her, Shirley found that this “Celine” was not as “unstable” as she had first imagined.

Or rather—the elf was a bit too stable.

Even if Shirley mentioned odd questions, Celine would just ignore them. Aside from “leading lost people to the Wall of Silence”, this elf seemed almost entirely unaffected by anything else.

So after they had been on the road for a while, Shirley began to boldly ask the elf all kinds of questions. Most of them never got any useful answer. But sometimes… a casual question brought a surprise.

“The corruption… began after the Creator disappeared,” Celine said, stopping. Unlike most times before, she answered Shirley’s question seriously. “We do not know what it truly is, but it devours and twists things in the forest, turning them into… shapes that cannot be understood. It is very dangerous.”

“After the Creator disappeared? The Creator disappeared?!” Shirley’s eyes widened at once. While she had not listened very well in class, she always

listened hard when the captain talked with the others, so of course she knew the stories about the elves. “The Creator you mean is… Saslokar?”

Right after the words left her mouth, Shirley felt something was wrong. She probably should not be calling a Great Demon God’s name so directly. It might upset the elf in front of her—but she soon saw she had worried too much.

Celine did not seem to notice Shirley speaking the main god’s name at all. She was sunk in some strange sadness, eyes lowered. “The Creator will return. The Creator is only inspecting the border. The Creator just went a little farther this time… Before the Creator returns, Atlantis will shelter all the elves within the Wall of Silence and the Sanctuary World… Atlantis will wait for the Creator to come back.”

For some reason, Shirley felt that Celine’s last sentence sounded like she was hypnotizing herself.

But before Shirley could ask anything else, she saw Celine—who just a second ago had been lost in sadness and a bit dazed—suddenly lift her head. At some point, the elf maiden’s eyes had become razor sharp. She gripped her long-handled battle-axe tightly and looked toward some point deep inside the forest.

Shirley tensed up at once: “Huh? What’s wrong?”

“Shh!” Celine lowered her voice. “Something foul has entered the forest…”

Something foul?

Shirley froze for a moment. Then she heard the rustling sounds coming from the nearby bushes, from deep under the ground, from the shadows of the trees, even from the air.

It felt like many strange, vicious things were writhing in the shadows and slowly gathering. A solid, heavy malice and a skin-crawling sense of being

watched suddenly filled the thick woods. Shirley felt Dog send her a surge of shared senses at once. Through the powerful senses of the Abyssal Hound, she saw the things that were “seeping” into the forest.

Tentacles made purely of shadow were gathering from every direction!

[They are Sunspawn remnants… not Annihilators?!]

Shirley froze again. She clearly remembered that when she had just entered the forest this time, Dog had said it sensed lingering traces of Annihilators. So why were the first ones she met these monsters that followed the Black Sun?

But her shock only flashed through her heart for a moment. Shirley reacted at once and went into fighting mode. She tensed all her muscles, watching the directions where the dark tentacles gathered, and warned Celine in a low voice: “Careful. These things use shadows to move, and they’re really tough. They’re especially hard to kill!”

Before she even finished, she saw ripples begin to spread under the shade of a tree not far away. The tentacles that had been hiding in shadow form quickly gathered into tall, thin human shapes, each one taking on a solid body.

But that exact moment, when they took on human form, was what Shirley had been waiting for.

In the next second, the chain went tight and the air howled. Shirley lunged a few steps toward the nearest figure and swung her arm with all her strength, sending out a meteor dog!

Dog flew out like a huge flail, slamming full-force into the first Sunspawn remnant to appear. With a dull thud like meat being pounded to mush, the tall, thin figure did not even have time to look around the dreamscape before it was smashed into a spray of corrupted flesh.

Almost at the same time, all around Shirley and Celine, in the crisscrossing shadows of the dense forest and bushes, more and more tall, thin figures began to appear…

Chapter 594: Battle and… Death?

One tall, thin shadow after another rose out of the air from every side. The rustling of tentacles squirming through the soil kept sounding, making Shirley's scalp crawl. The remnants of the Sun gathered and pressed closer. They stood up straight from the shadows, showing their terrifying, twisted faces and corrupting the forest inside this dream.

Chains howled through the air. With sharp booms of compressed and torn wind, Shirley rushed back and forth across the clearing among the trees. She charged at every remnant of the Sun that had just stepped into the dreamwalking state and had not yet found its footing. She raised her hand and brought Dog down again and again, swinging the chain wildly with the monstrous strength she had gained from her symbiotic pact with the Abyssal demons—swinging the Abyssal demon Dog itself at the same time—knocking those not-quite-human horrors to the ground and banishing them from this dream.

But the number of intruders still grew. The remnants of the Sun that she had knocked down for the moment climbed up from the shadows again and again.

The dim forest, full of shifting light and shadow, became the perfect field for the remnants of the Sun to move freely and rebuild themselves. corrupted flesh that she had smashed away dissolved into the shadows, then gathered again in the shadows. Tall, thin silhouettes kept appearing all around. The moment Shirley's movements slowed even a little, they launched ruthless attacks at once.

A sharp shriek suddenly rose behind her. A spike-like tentacle thrust out of the air itself and stabbed straight at the back of Shirley's neck. Her hair stood on end at once, but when she tried to dodge, it was already too late—

There was a dull, wet sound as flesh was cut, but the pain she expected did not come. Shirley, already braced to take the hit head-on, turned her head in shock and saw a battle-axe sweeping past from behind her. The blade spun, then rose and fell again, cleanly chopping apart two more "spikes" that had lunged in for a surprise attack.

The edge of the axe blade shone with a dim blue light, as if it was covered by some burning force field that scorched and twisted the nearby air. An elven maiden named Celine held the strange long-handled axe in one hand. While she beat back the attackers and guarded Shirley's flank, she stared in confused shock at the tall black figures still appearing and gathering from all around. At last she could not help asking: "What… are these things?"

"They're definitely not something that grew in your forest, that's for sure!" Shirley shouted as she swung her chain high and brought Dog down, smashing apart a knot of shadows that was gathering not far ahead. "These things are so damn hard to deal with!"

Celine raised her axe to block another attack coming from the opposite side. Hearing Shirley's shout, she froze for a second, then frowned without thinking and said: "Those words are a bit rude."

"If you don't swear out loud, the curse words just rot in your stomach. That's disgusting," Shirley said with a wild, bright grin. She stepped on a mass of flesh that was still wriggling and pulling itself back together. Black smoky mist rose from the chain in her hands, and she looked almost cheerful. "I like to keep clean. I never let curse words stay in my gut overnight."

Celine listened in a daze to Shirley's "theory." She seemed to be trying hard to understand this logic, but in the end she only frowned and shook her head. She turned her attention back to the enemies around them and muttered: "You're talking nonsense."

A tentacle that swelled and shrank without a steady shape, its surface crawling with eyes and teeth, suddenly wrapped around Shirley's arm. Her heart jolted. She used all her strength to tear free of its grip, then forced back the clump of shadows where the tentacle had risen from. Only then did she glance toward Celine without thinking.

A strange doubt rose in her heart. Maybe it was just her imagination, but in these short few minutes, this elf named Celine seemed to have become more… human than before.

Was it because of the sudden attack? Because they were fighting side by side?

Shirley remembered how Celine had seemed when they first met. Back then, Celine had not shown so many emotional reactions. She had expressions of joy, anger, sorrow, and calm, but those reactions felt more like something designed ahead of time. She would only keep repeating the plan to head for the Wall of Silence. Besides that, no matter what Shirley said, Celine hardly reacted. Almost never was there surprise, confusion, or lively pushback.

Shirley did not know anything about psychology or behavior studies and had no words for the wrongness she felt. But her life experience had trained her to sense changes in other people's moods. She could clearly feel that something about Celine was changing—she just could not figure out why.

But she did not have much time to think about it.

After their first confusion and panic, the remnants of the Sun had adjusted and found their footing here. Now they were truly dangerous.

A vague shadow flashed at the edge of her sight. In a rush, Shirley only had time to yank her chain back and barely dodge the attack. The next second, another spike shot out from the shadows on the ground nearby and stabbed into the arm that still belonged to a human.

The sharp pain made her curse without thinking. Dog rushed in at once from the side and bit through the fleshy spike that had formed from the shadows. Shirley pulled back in a hurry, leaving that deadly range of attack. She had not even let out a breath of relief when she suddenly heard rustling behind her again.

She turned her head on instinct and saw a tall, thin shadow burst up from the ground right in front of her. The next moment, countless tentacles poured out from inside the shadow's "long coat" and wrapped around her arms and neck. The huge force that surged through those tentacles yanked her forward in an instant. She only had time to gasp before she was dragged up close to the shadow.

The tall shadow lifted its "head" toward her. A swollen, twisted mass of flesh pushed out from the collar of the long coat and suddenly opened like a flower bud. Right in front of Shirley, eyes, countless sharp teeth, and many writhing tendrils like mad tongues opened inside that blooming flesh flower.

In that brief moment, it felt as if a thousand voices exploded in Shirley's mind. Endless screams and whispers piled over one another, forcing their way into her head. Those howls and murmurs seemed to be trying to pass some message to her, but just as she felt she was about to understand them, most of the information slipped out of her mind, leaving no trace.

In this sudden link, her mind kept only one vague and strangely meaningless line:

“…Find their… the Sun…”

Shirley seemed to sink into boundless chaos. Endless darkness and emptiness wrapped around her. Countless noises roared over her. She slowly opened her eyes wide, her divine gaze blankly fixed on the blooming flower of flesh before her. Her will to resist felt peeled away from her body. Dog’s voice faded in her mind and drifted into the distance…

But in the next second, a thunderous boom exploded deep in her consciousness. In that endless darkness, Shirley seemed to see a ghost-green flame jump once. The flame shone on her soul and sent a sharp stab of pain through her head. The next instant, she snapped back to herself.

The tall, thin shadow came into focus again. The “head” made of foul, blooming flesh was shaking violently right in front of her. This remnant of the Sun let out a series of sharp hisses and howls. It seemed shocked. It could not understand why its corruption had failed to enter its prey’s mind —but soon, it no longer had any need to be shocked.

Clusters of ghost-green flame suddenly appeared on the surfaces of the many eyes inside the flesh flower. In the blink of an eye, the reflections in those eyes turned into real, spreading fire. Flames of spirit form burst out from the remnant’s “head,” blazing outward from the inside and burning this dream invader with fierce speed.

The monster shrieked and twitched. Under the burning of the spirit form flames, it convulsed hard, then curled up into a knot of strange black matter. Flames that poured from its body spread outward at once, like hunters that had caught the scent of prey, flowing toward the other remnants of the Sun that were gathering all around.

The fire spread like the wind. Sparks leaped from one place to another, and one remnant of the Sun after another caught fire. In almost the blink of an eye, they all turned into blazing sacred beacon torches.

Shirley stared in shock. The horrible feeling from when her mind had nearly been corrupted now cooled into a thin, icy aftertaste. But as the spirit flame spread, that lingering fear turned into a different emotion. She began to laugh. Wild pride showed on her face. She raised the black iron chain in her hand and looked with smug delight at the remnants of the Sun howling and struggling in the flames: “Trash like you think you can pull off some kind of mental corruption? I’m under the captain’s protection, damn it!”

The remnants of the Sun, of course, did not answer her. One blazing sacred beacon torch after another collapsed in the fire. Before they could withdraw from the dream, they turned into drifting ashes in the forest.

As for Shirley, she still looked smug, but she did not truly relax until the last “sacred beacon torch” fell. Only then did she turn her head toward Celine.

Celine’s voice reached her first: “Shirley, I feel… not very well…”

A heavy panic and unease hit her. Shirley’s heart clenched. She ran to Celine at once, and the next second, she saw the change happening to her.

The elven maiden’s feet had already begun to sink into the ground without anyone noticing. Dark, root-like shapes split from her legs, more and more of them, and reached down into the soil. She lifted her head and looked toward Shirley. She seemed to want to raise her arms, but bark-like growths were already spreading over them—growing stiff and harder to move.

Chapter 595: Unexpected Reunion

Shirley stared, dumbfounded, at what was happening before her eyes. It was like facing a twisted nightmare. For a moment she did not know how to react at all.

Celine slowly reached her right hand toward her. Shirley walked over on instinct, as if she meant to grab Celine's fingers. But before she could touch Celine, the elf's arm was completely covered in rough bark-like material. In the last second, all Shirley touched was a hard, coarse branch. Then the "branch" began to grow quickly, stretching upward, taller and taller toward the sky…

Celine's face disappeared inside the tangle of branches that burst into full growth. In the last instant before the transformation was complete, she opened her eyes a little wider. It was as if she suddenly understood something. She looked at Shirley, as if she wanted to tell her something. Then her expression froze at that moment and completely melted into the tree.

Now she had become a small tree with long, slender branches.

Shirley stared blankly at this unbelievable sight. She replayed the whole process of Celine changing into a tree in her mind and thought of that last look Celine had given her. For a long time, she simply stood there without moving.

What had happened? Why had it turned out like this?

How could an elf turn into a tree?

A faint wind suddenly blew nearby. There was malice hidden in the sound of the wind as it drew closer. Shirley finally woke from her shock. She snapped her head up and looked toward the source of that malice. In the dim forest, she saw a dark red glow and a haze like smoky shadows appear faintly, then fade away again.

Dog sensed the hateful aura at once—the aura of Abyssal demons.

“Annihilators! They were hiding in the shadows of those remnants of the Sun just now!”

Hearing Dog’s low growl, Shirley finally understood what had happened.

It was the Annihilators who had drawn those remnants of the Sun here. Maybe they were working together, or maybe it was only using them. They had wanted to use the hands of the remnants of the Sun to get rid of her and Celine. But things had gone beyond their plans. When one remnant of the Sun tried to corrupt her mind, the captain’s flame was stirred, turned back on them, and wiped out all the attackers.

Before this, the strong presence of the remnants of the Sun had covered the auras of the Annihilators. Now that the cultists knew they had been exposed, they made the quick choice to run.

Shirley looked toward the dark part of the forest. She took a step, then hesitated. Her eyes swept across the clearing. The remnants of the Sun that had died in the spirit flame were all curled and twisted into ash. The ashes slowly faded into the air. Faint ghostly green flames still burned between some of the ash piles, but they were shrinking and going out.

The captain’s flame was fading—that was not a power she could control.

Shirley knew very well that the “victory” just now had little to do with her. And she had no idea if that flame would appear again the next time she

faced danger. Maybe… the mark the captain left on her could only work once.

If she chased the cultists blindly and then found in a real fight that she could not beat them, they would be in real trouble.

But her hesitation lasted only a second or two. Before the drifting smoke and mist moved out of Dog's sensing range, she bit her lip, spat to the side, and ran toward the deeper darkness.

She ran past the small tree that Celine had become. The thin twigs at the tip of the tree brushed Shirley's shoulder. Branches and leaves swayed and rustled softly.

After running through the forest for who knew how long, Shirley and Dog finally slowed down.

"Their scent has scattered up ahead, and it's fading fast," Dog said as it lifted its ugly big head and turned it left and right in the air. The blood-red glow in its eye sockets flickered. "There must be demons among them that are good at hiding their tracks. Maybe a Death-Omen Bird… tsk, what a bother."

"We lost them?" Shirley muttered, unwilling to give up. "I thought we'd finally catch one or two this time…"

Dog shook its head and did not say more. It only tried again to tell which way the fading trail truly led.

Just then, the sound of footsteps from somewhere in the forest cut off what it was doing with Shirley.

Shirley tensed at once. She raised her chain, bent forward, and looked toward the sound. But the figure that stepped out from behind the trees and bushes was not the cultist she had expected.

An elven maiden in light hunting clothes, carrying a strange long-handled battle-axe, walked out of the woods.

Shirley's taut stance went stiff. She stared in shock at the elven maiden coming out of the trees, at her familiar face. Even though she already knew she was inside a strange dream, a sense of absurd unease rose quietly in her heart. Then she heard the elven maiden speak to her in surprise:

"You didn't receive the evacuation order? Why are you still moving outside the Wall of Silence?!"

Shirley opened her mouth. A flood of words rushed up in her chest, but when she tried to speak, she could not form even one. She looked oddly at the "Celine" standing before her again. Her first instinct was to greet her, but she quickly realized this Celine did not know her at all—this was no longer the Celine who had taken her toward the Wall of Silence before.

While she was still frozen, a second set of footsteps sounded behind the elven maiden. Shirley looked that way in surprise. A familiar figure in a black dress, hugging an enormous stuffed rabbit doll in her arms, stepped into view.

"Miss Lucretia?"

"Shirley?" Lucretia walked out of the forest. Seeing the familiar figure at the fork in the path, the "sea witch" showed surprise as well and said: "I really didn't expect this…"

This unexpected meeting left both of them a bit stunned. Shirley grabbed Dog and looked Lucretia up and down, then glanced at the elven maiden standing beside her. After a moment, Shirley cautiously stepped back half a pace and said: "Just to be safe—"

Lucretia spoke right away: "Identity check."

Shirley answered quickly: "Where was Alice's head yesterday at noon?"

“In the pot,” Lucretia replied without a pause. Then she asked at once: “What is my father’s biggest hobby right now?”

“Fishing, walking the dog, and feeding pigeons—you pass.”

“Yes, you pass,” Lucretia said. She clearly relaxed a little. She lowered the conductor’s baton she had been gripping and set the stuffed rabbit doll down on the ground. “This dream is very strange. A bit more caution never hurts.”

Shirley nodded along. Just then, the elven maiden Celine finally spoke: “You know each other?”

“Yes, friend,” Lucretia answered lightly.

Shirley could not help giving the elf beside her another complicated look. Then she turned to Lucretia and asked quickly: “Did you see any sign of those Annihilators on your way here?”

“Annihilators?” Lucretia frowned. “I didn’t see any—did you run into them?”

“Not just Annihilators, I also ran into a bunch of trash from the Sun,” Shirley said with some regret. “Too bad those Annihilators ran off in the end…”

She then quickly told Lucretia what had happened to her just now, including how she had almost been corrupted by a remnant of the Sun and how the captain’s flame had appeared and saved her.

But she did not mention the Celine who had been with her, nor that unbelievable scene of Celine turning into a small tree.

Another elven maiden named Celine was standing right next to them, listening curiously to her and Lucretia’s conversation.

Until she understood what was going on with all these “Celines,” she had to avoid causing any unknown changes in them as much as she could.

“Dog and I chased them all the way here. We were almost on them, but they still got away,” Shirley said, shaking her head with regret after she finished her story. “There was a Death-Omen Bird among them. That’s a kind of demon that’s good at hiding its aura and confusing senses. Dog isn’t good at dealing with that thing.”

Lucretia lifted her head. She looked thoughtfully at the forest around them, which looked almost the same no matter which way you turned. After a moment of thinking, she suddenly said: “They shouldn’t have gotten far… You just said they bolted right after they saw the spirit flame kill those remnants of the Sun?”

“That’s right,” Shirley said with a nod. “They ran fast and didn’t care about their ‘allies’ at all.”

“So they were terrified by my father’s flame. They must have been full of fear when they ran, right?”

“…I guess so,” Shirley answered, not too sure and a little confused. “Is there something wrong with that?”

Lucretia did not answer her. Instead, she lowered her head and looked at the stuffed rabbit doll sitting on the ground in a daze. She said: “Rabby, I know you’re listening.”

The stuffed rabbit doll swayed slowly from side to side and gave a tiny, complaining sound: “Rabby doesn’t like cultists. Their minds stink, and there are really gross things in there…”

Lucretia said nothing. She simply raised the conductor’s baton in her hand.

The stuffed rabbit doll stood up at once. It patted the dirt off its body and muttered as it worked: “All right, all right, Rabby knows, Rabby will go

look for them… You have to remember to bring Rabby back!”

“Go… while their fear still hasn’t faded.”

“Okay,” the stuffed rabbit doll answered. Then, right in front of Shirley, it exploded with a bang. A cloud of white smoke poured out of it, drawn in rough lines like a hand-drawn picture. The smoke rose and spread, instantly covering its silly yet creepy figure. As the smoke thinned and drifted away, the stuffed rabbit doll vanished from Shirley’s sight along with it.

Chapter 596: Inherited Fishing Talent

Now Shirley once again set out on the road to that legendary Wall of Silence, together with Lucretia and still under the mental guidance of the elf maiden named Celine.

They walked through a dense forest where light and shadow tangled together. They stepped along paths covered in fallen branches and leaves, pushed through thorns and bushes. From deep in the woods came the cries of small animals and birds from time to time, but those sounds only made the forest feel even colder and more lonely. Looking at Celine’s back as Celine walked ahead, Shirley even had a brief illusion. She felt as if time had turned back and she had returned to that recent trek through the forest when she had followed this same guide.

Nothing seemed to have changed. The forest always looked the same. The noises around them were the same. And the two “Celines” looked completely identical.

Only the witch walking beside her, who sometimes turned into colored scraps of paper to hurry along, reminded Shirley that things had already changed.

By now, without the elf maiden noticing, Shirley had told Lucretia everything that had happened before. She had also shared it with everyone else trapped in the state of Dreamwalking, including the captain who was acting outside the dream. The captain’s preparations before the

Dreamwalking had worked very well. The Power of Flame tied everyone together. That link was even more useful than Shirley had expected.

After learning what had happened to “the other Celine,” Lucretia could not help feeling different when she looked at the elf maiden walking in front of them.

That Celine who had moved together with Shirley had turned into a tree in the end. Before she completed that transformation, she seemed to have had something she wanted to tell Shirley.

So would this Celine also suddenly turn into a tree?

Over on Nina and Morris’s side, they had also met a guide who called herself “Celine.” What about that Celine? Would the same change happen to her?

In the end, what were these “Celines” that appeared in the Nameless One’s dream?

At first, Lucretia had only thought “Celine” was a mental entity, formed from the dream’s deep, chaotic thoughts. But now all kinds of clues showed that Celine had a special nature far beyond what they had imagined. This elf who called herself Celine seemed to have a very complex link with this forest and with the entire dream of the Nameless One. It was far more than a simple tie between a dream and a mind-born spirit.

The process of her transformation into a tree might be revealing the true nature of that link.

The elf maiden walking in front suddenly slowed her steps. She turned and looked back at Lucretia and Shirley, who were falling far behind, and waved hard: “Hurry up. The forest is too dangerous right now. Once we reach the Wall of Silence, you can rest.”

Lucretia glanced back at Shirley and Dog beside her, then they all quickened their pace together.

As she hurried to catch up, Shirley muttered under her breath: “Can that big Little Doll really find those sneaky cultists? I still feel like it’s not very reliable…”

“Rabby does act up sometimes, but as long as I give clear orders, it won’t cause trouble,” Lucretia said softly. “Hunting inside dreams is what it does best. It will track them and chase them all the way to the Mortal Realm, and then we can find where those cultists are really hiding.”

“So what is that big rabbit supposed to be, exactly?” Dog grumbled at her side. “I smelled… a human scent on it. It’s definitely not some simple magic construct, not even an ordinary evil spirit or some run-of-the-mill demon. And it’s not just the rabbit. The other things on your ship give me the same feeling. They all feel strange to me.”

“Human scent?” Lucretia looked at Dog and smiled a little. “Ah, as expected of a Abyssal Hound. Your senses really are sharp. Yes, it’s a human scent. It’s the human scent from a piece of my soul.”

Dog froze. “…Huh?”

“It’s nothing that big,” Lucretia said. “When Rabby first met me, it tore off a piece of my soul. It probably never thought that bite of soul would take away its freedom forever. A lot of the things on the Radiant Star are like that. They all came from the boundary regions or from the Spirit Realm. They were dangerous beings, and for a time they thought they were hunters and saw me as their prey. For me, that is a great convenience.”

Lucretia spoke slowly, still wearing that faint smile.

“I use my soul as bait and search for servants at the boundary,” she went on. “Souls cursed by Subspace make the best poison and the best chains. Those

who mistake themselves for hunters end up bound by my soul. I sew them into cloth, pour them into bottles, carve them into wood. They become part of the Radiant Star. I need these servants, because I need assistants for my journeys along the boundary, and humans… humans die too easily."

The sea witch finished her explanation and lowered her head to look at Dog. "Your sense is very accurate. That ship is full of tiny traces of 'human scent.' You really don't need to be so shocked."

Dog and Shirley both stared in a daze. Lucretia's words had clearly stunned them. For a while, the two "people" said nothing at all.

Seeing this, Lucretia only smiled again. Pleased by Shirley and Dog's silence, she turned back and continued to follow in Celine's footsteps.

When the sea witch had gone a bit farther ahead, Shirley finally shook the chain in her hand. Even though she was speaking through the mental link, she still could not help lowering her voice: "DogDog, isn't this what the captain called… what was it… baiting the spot? She's using herself as bait?"

"Sounds like it," Dog muttered quietly through the mental link. "The captain mentioned this when he was teaching me fishing tricks."

"No wonder she's the captain's daughter…" Shirley could not stop herself from sighing. "That whole family seems to be good at fishing…"

"Tyrian doesn't seem very good at it."

"He fished up so many submersibles from the sea back then! He didn't reel them up by hand, sure, but he was still one of the people in charge…"

"That counts?"

"Just answer this: did he or did he not pull them out of the sea?"

"…"

…

Duncan quietly shut down his “monitoring” of Shirley and Lucretia’s side.

He sat in a “chair” drawn from tangled lines and piled colors. Words like “baiting the spot” and “fishing” kept circling in his head. After a while, he turned his gaze a little and looked at the “mirror” nearby, shaped from uneven lines. He spoke to Agatha’s face in the mirror: “She never remembers proper knowledge, but anything else, she picks up so fast. If Shirley could put even a tenth of that effort into memorizing vocabulary, she wouldn’t be fighting Alice, that solid blockhead, over test scores.”

Agatha stayed quiet for a few seconds before she finally broke the silence. “To be honest, I also think Miss Lucretia has very excellent ‘fishing skills’…”

Duncan waved his hand. “Anyway, we don’t have to worry about Shirley and Lucretia for now. Being together is much safer than moving alone, and maybe that rabbit called Rabby really can catch those elusive cultists. What matters more now… is this ship.”

He rose from the chair and let his eyes pass over the piled, twisted colors and lines around him, picking out the outlines of different parts of the room from those lines. After getting used to this dizzying chaos, he had already recognized many familiar things in here.

There was a bed, chairs, a table, and other basic furniture, all placed roughly where they should be in the Mortal Realm. But when it came to details, like what was on the table now or what hung on the walls, everything blurred into messy patches of color.

It was just as Duncan had guessed. In the Mortal Realm, Goathead did not dare to spy on the true state of the captain’s cabin. At most, he had caught a quick glimpse inside when the captain opened the door. Those vague

impressions had become the crooked lines and color blocks that formed this room.

Outside this room, though, the Vanished had been almost perfectly rebuilt one to one. That was because, in the Mortal Realm, Goathead knew every part of the Vanished by heart, except for the captain's cabin.

This eerie version of the Vanished had grown out of the "shadow" of the Vanished in the Mortal Realm. But it was not a simple one-to-one swap. In this change, Goathead's "awareness" and "memory" had played the key role.

By now the facts were clear. This ship was the dream of his first mate, even though Goathead had no idea he was dreaming at all.

But this place was also Atlantis's dream. At the very least, there was some kind of "link" between it and Atlantis's dream.

Duncan raised his hand. A tiny flame appeared in the air in front of him. The flame rippled like water and spread quickly in all directions, but it stopped when it reached the edge of this "chaotic room," then rippled and reflected back.

This was the result of Duncan's "tests" over the past while.

Inside this room, which Goathead could not perceive, Duncan could summon his own flames freely without worrying about waking Atlantis like last time. But outside the room, he could only move the fire seeds he had mapped onto the ship in advance. Any extra flame might wake Atlantis and end the Nameless One's dream too soon.

So… was there a safe way to fully take control of this ship, deepen his link with Atlantis, and still avoid startling her again and stirring up her resistance?

Deep in thought, Duncan lifted his head and looked toward the door.

Maybe he was making this too complicated. Maybe it was actually very simple.

After a moment’s hesitation, he told Agatha to stay in this “safe room” for now, then stepped out.

That muddle-headed Goathead still stared blankly at the edge of the chart table and did not react at all when Duncan appeared. Duncan walked straight past him, past the room of the enchanted sea chart, and out through the cabin door. Then he followed the route he knew by heart, climbed the stairs beside and behind the captain’s cabin, and came out onto the aft deck.

In the endless darkness and slowly drifting mist, something appeared in his sight. It seemed to be quietly waiting for him, and had been waiting for a long time.

It was the helm of the Vanished.

“…Time to take the wheel again.”

Chapter 597: Stream of Light

Ever since he had discovered this strange Vanished sailing through endless darkness and fog, Duncan had been very careful not to try and seize its wheel.

He had not known what this ship really was, nor how it might react if he tried to “take control.”

But now he knew the ship was the shadow of the Vanished, and that it had changed because Goathead had slipped into Dreamwalking without knowing it. That knowledge eased many of Duncan’s worries.

It was time for this ship that sailed through dreams to learn who its real captain was.

Duncan slowly walked up onto the helm platform at the stern. His steps passed the iron hooks and ropes nearby. The ropes lay silent, coiled and waiting in the dark. In the middle of the platform, the dull-colored wheel rocked a little from side to side, as if it was still making tiny course changes here in the dreamscape, as if Goathead was still faithfully steering it.

Duncan came to the wheel and took a slow breath. He could not help remembering the scene from the first time he had stood here and set his hand on the helm.

He shook off those stray thoughts. Then he reached out and slowly gripped one of the smooth, cold handles at the rim of the wheel. Along with the smooth, chilly feel came a faint resistance.

Duncan ignored the resistance that seeped through the dream itself. He called on the “safe” fire seeds he had sent onto the ship earlier and ordered them to gather at the helm while he tightened his grip on the wheel.

The next second, thin threads of flame appeared in the darkness out of nowhere. Spirit-form fire flared up and in an instant set the helm platform at the stern ablaze. Duncan’s body turned into a half-transparent spirit form within the flames, and fire swept over the whole helm, wheel and all.

In that instant, Duncan felt the ship changing under his hands. It became clear and solid in his mind, just like the Vanished in the Mortal Realm. He sensed its deck, its masts, each sail and every rope. He sensed the dark, hidden rooms and corridors below the deck…

The whole ship groaned and creaked. This Vanished, shaped from a shadow and formed by the power of dreams, suddenly seemed to awaken. It finally recognized its captain. Every part of the ship seemed to cheer. The ropes, barrels, and other things that had been still a moment ago started to sway in the dark.

Right after that, as the spirit-form sails slowly filled, Duncan felt the ghost ship begin to speed up. Before, it had drifted slowly in the dark mist. Now it moved as if it had a clear destination and was sailing toward some point in the darkness.

Duncan felt that sudden change with surprise, especially the sudden burst of speed. But before he could sense what lay ahead on this course, a voice suddenly came from nowhere and went straight into his mind: “…Who is there?”

It was a young girl’s voice, a little hazy and confused, sounding half awake and half asleep. It echoed everywhere in the darkness. In the very next instant, Duncan felt light and shadow bloom before his eyes. Then a huge

structure appeared out of the darkness ahead, and dim phantom lights rose in the ship's path.

It looked like a giant whirlpool. But inside the whirlpool he saw countless shapes like vines or branches. Endless vines and boughs surged toward the Vanished from ahead and, in the blink of an eye, wrapped almost every inch of space beyond the railings. In Duncan's sight, that vast plant structure filled everything and stretched and moved backward as the Vanished sailed on.

It felt as if the ship had suddenly "flown" into a tunnel woven from some huge plant. Vines and branches twisted together to form the walls and the dome of that tunnel. A crushing sense of pressure came with it. At the same time, countless tiny lights appeared along the vines and then flowed together like water.

Those lights finally reached the Vanished. They began to spread along the deck and the sides of the hull, creeping closer and closer to the stern where Duncan stood. Something seemed to be gathering inside the glow, but it never took on a clear shape. The lights simply gathered and drew nearer, as if searching for something.

Under that overwhelming sight and strange radiance, Duncan held the wheel tight. He controlled himself and refused to step away from the helm no matter what happened. He watched the dark vines and branches slide past outside the railings. He felt the Vanished's speed slowly drop, as if some unseen force was dragging at the ship. Then the wandering lights finally gathered near him again, and he heard the young, childlike voice once more.

"Who is it? Who is there?"

Duncan stared hard at the light. He watched it drift near him and wander around the helm without purpose, while the voice kept sounding in his

mind.

“Have you come back, Saslokar? …Have you come home? You have been gone so long…

“I cannot see you… Where are you? Can I open my eyes now? Is it all over?

“I… I cannot open my eyes, Saslokar. I am a little scared. I cannot see anything… but something is here…

“I kept them all safe. I built a wall. You will see them when you come back… but I cannot see you. Are you there? Have you come back?”

The light called out again and again. It drifted and gathered around the helm, then broke apart into blind, chaotic streams. More than once, a strand of light flowed right up to the wheel and even brushed against Duncan’s coat and sleeves.

Yet “she” seemed unable to sense Duncan at all.

“She” could not see anything, as if the owner of that voice and Duncan were locked in different dimensions, living in different times and spaces.

Duncan watched the streams of light wandering past. He listened to the voice that seemed to speak straight in his mind. When the glow drew close, he could even feel a faint warmth from it. The words, repeated over and over, sounded like they carried many vital clues. He frowned, hesitated for a moment, then finally reached out. One hand stayed on the wheel. The other reached toward one of the streams of light.

The light touched his palm, bringing a warmth that felt both real and unreal.

Then the little stream of light flowed straight through his arm. Its warmth faded away. As if it belonged to another dimension, the light passed on toward the stern.

But in that brief contact, Duncan learned, or rather confirmed, the name of the light and the voice. She was Atlantis, the elves' World Tree.

That name stamped itself into Duncan's mind as pure information, as if showing the corrupting nature of knowledge itself.

Duncan blanked out for a second. Then he suddenly felt the deck under his feet tremble.

A moment later, the tremor ran through the whole ship. The Vanished, sailing through the dark mist, began to shake violently. The spirit-form sails went out in the darkness at once. Cracks spread over the deck. Everything that made up the ship started to fade and fall apart. Even the wheel in Duncan's hands began to lose its solid feel.

Duncan froze, then realized what was happening.

The dream was losing stability. The time to "wake up" had come.

Yet this time he had gone out of his way to avoid using flames that would disturb Atlantis. In that brief contact, he had not felt any sign that Atlantis was waking. So why was the dream still falling apart so fast?

…

A sudden wild wind in the desert tore Vanna from her thoughts. She sprang up from behind the stones where she had been sheltering from the wind and looked toward the direction where sand and dust were rising.

Walls of sand were rearing up in the distance. Everything in the dust and haze grew vague at great speed. The jagged rocks became twisted and unreal, as if they might vanish from this world at any moment.

After a brief moment of shock, Vanna received a message from the captain.

The Nameless One's dream was losing stability. This dream was about to end.

The flying sand and the twisting, fading horizon showed that the borders of the dream were racing toward her.

Vanna quickly turned her head and looked across the almost dead campfire.

The old giant there was lifting his head. Calm fire burned in his deep, hollow, stone-like eyes.

“Traveler, it seems the time has come to say goodbye.”

Vanna paused, then suddenly understood. “How did you… know…?”

“I do not know what is going to happen,” the giant said gently. He slowly rose from the pile of rocks. His body stood in the wind like a tower. Lowering his head, he gazed calmly into Vanna’s eyes with a kind of divine gaze. “But I can feel that a journey is ending for now. You are about to leave, aren’t you? You do not belong to this ruined world. There is still life in you, and this world has not seen life for a very long time.”

Vanna opened her mouth but could not think of what to say. In this short moment before the dream woke, it seemed she had time only to say farewell.

The giant smiled and bent down to pick up his strange, long staff.

Vanna noticed that there were now a few more symbols on the surface of that huge “gatekeeper’s cane,” which was even taller than the giant himself.

They were letters. They carried a strange, blurry sense of familiarity. For a second, she felt she was about to understand them. But in the next instant, the meaning of the letters slipped from her mind like running water.

They were words she did not know.

“Traveler, perhaps we will meet again,” the giant’s voice came from above, breaking Vanna’s daze. “And maybe it will be soon.”

Vanna started. “Why?”

The giant pointed at the gatekeeper’s cane. “Because there is a sentence here that I have not finished carving yet.”

Vanna blinked and had just opened her mouth to ask something when the storm of sand rushed at her from behind. In the rising dust, the world in front of her shook and collapsed at great speed.

A second later, the broken world came back together and turned into a familiar living room, a familiar table, and a familiar roof.

Familiar faces reappeared in front of her.

Chapter 598: Layered Space-Time

On the waters near Lightwind Harbor, far from the main shipping routes and covered in thin mist, the huge and imposing silhouette of the Vanished slowly cruised through the fog.

Then the sea surface suddenly rippled in a strange, unreal way. The ghost ship's reflection rose and fell in those ripples. For a very brief instant, the reflection seemed about to gather itself up out of the water, but in the next moment everything returned to normal.

In the captain's cabin, on the edge of the chart table, the wooden carving of Goathead suddenly turned its head in confusion. Its base gave a faint creak as it lifted its head and looked around. After a long moment, it muttered in puzzlement: "Why did that just feel so strange…"

On the wall in one corner of the room, the ancient oval scrying mirror now held layers of rolling black mist. The figure of Agatha stood within the glass, quietly watching Goathead on the table.

Goathead finally noticed the gaze from the side. It snapped its head around, saw Agatha, and let out a yell: "Hey… you scared me! Why are you staring at me first thing in the morning?"

As it spoke, it shook its head again, as if it suddenly remembered something: "Right, Lady Agatha, where did you go last night? I felt like your presence wasn't on the ship… Don't you usually wander through the mirrors at night to patrol?"

Agatha did not answer Goathead's question right away. She kept quietly watching the every move of this "First Mate." Only after a long silence did she speak: "You didn't feel anything last night? You didn't notice any anomaly when I left?"

"No," Goathead said after a brief pause, then slowly realized something. "Wait, what do you mean… did something happen again last night?"

"Mm. The captain should be coming to see you soon," Agatha said with a frown and a small nod. Then she asked: "Just now you said you felt strange. What exactly was that about?"

Goathead thought for a moment before realising she meant the muttered comment it had just made to itself. It still had no idea why this usually calm and gentle former Gatekeeper was acting so strangely this morning, but it still answered: "I don't really know how to describe it. I just… jolted. Like I was spacing out and someone suddenly tapped me on the shoulder."

Agatha gave Goathead a puzzled look and studied it for a moment: "…Do you have shoulders?"

"Then it was a tap on the head—just a figure of speech, you get it," Goathead said, shaking its head. "Maybe I zoned out a bit while steering. There must have been a bit of swell on the sea just now that shook me awake…"

"There was no swell. The sea stayed calm the whole time—only the dreamscape rippled," Agatha said, shaking her head. "You were dreaming just now."

Goathead froze. After several seconds it finally let out a sound: "…Huh?"

…

Looking at the city streets, now completely back to normal in the morning light, Duncan slightly furrowed his brow. His face showed a thoughtful

expression.

The two dolls stood quietly behind him.

He stood thinking like that for who knew how long, then suddenly muttered under his breath: “It seems that no matter how long I stay ‘over there,’ no matter how the Nameless One’s dream ends, when I ‘wake up,’ time in the Mortal Realm is always back at dawn…”

Alice turned her head to look at Lunie, then turned back to the captain and scratched her hair in confusion: “Uh… did you stay ‘over there’ for a long time this time?”

“From how it felt, I lingered in that dark, misty space for almost twice as long as last time—right up until the dream jolted awake again,” Duncan said, nodding slowly. “But it seems that the time node in the Mortal Realm was still the same as before. It was still dawn, just as the Sun was rising. That does… fit how dreams work, a little.”

He paused, searching for the words, then explained to Alice: “The way time feels passing inside a dream is chaotic. A single second and a thousand years of felt time might both be only an instant in the Mortal Realm, and everything gets corrected at the moment you wake up.”

Alice thought about it, then shook her head in confusion: “I don’t get it…”

“It’s fine. It’s not important,” Duncan said with a smile, pushing aside the messy thoughts in his mind for now. He stepped forward and ruffled Alice’s hair. “Let’s go back first. This exploration… was very fruitful.”

With the two dolls in tow, Duncan quickly returned to the witch’s manor at No. 99 Crown Street. His crew members had already come back from the dreamscape and had gathered again in the living room.

When Duncan walked into the living room, Vanna, Morris, and the others were already talking about their own experiences in the Nameless One’s

dream.

Unlike last time, when everyone fell into dreamwalking with no prophetic omen at all, this round of dreamwalking had been done with preparation. Using flame, Duncan had left everyone a temporary mark, making sure the crew members could at least exchange basic information inside the Nameless One's dream. So when they woke up this time, no one needed to spend extra effort explaining what they had gone through. They could focus their energy on discussing the various clues instead.

Duncan's arrival broke off the crew's discussion. Morris and the others all got to their feet to salute the captain. Nina, however, rushed over and threw herself at him, looking especially happy: "Uncle Duncan!"

Duncan gave Nina a gentle hug, then let his gaze sweep over the figures in the room. He saw Lucretia sitting on the sofa opposite the coffee table with a rather odd look on her face, and spread his hands with a smile: "Do you want a hug too?"

The witch of the sea thought for a moment, then shook her head: "No."

Duncan chuckled and went to sit in his own seat. His expression quickly turned serious: "All right, then let's get to business. We can skip the basic exchange of information. What we need to focus on now are two new developments.

"First, the 'Celine' who appeared before Shirley, Morris, and Nina.

"Second, the 'giant' Vanna met, the one who claimed to be a deity."

He raised his head and let his gaze fall on Morris.

"I want to hear your thoughts first, Morris."

"The fact that multiple 'Celines' appeared in the dream means we need to adjust our earlier judgment of her," Morris said. He took off his blessed

monocle and began to wipe it as he spoke. “Before, we judged that ‘Celine’ was only a mental entity that appeared in the Nameless One’s dream, like a native resident. Her actions did not seem closely tied to how the dream itself operated. But now, it seems that is not the case…

“Once the range and time of our activity in the dream pass a certain limit, a ‘Celine’ appears near us and tries to guide our minds toward that place called the ‘Wall of Silence.’ That kind of mental guidance might be a mechanism of the Nameless One’s dream itself.

“In other words, that elf called ‘Celine’ may be the avatar form of some rule within the Nameless One’s dream. She is not a mind of her own, but a mechanism. When the conditions are right, she is triggered. When the conditions change, she may vanish.”

As Morris spoke, his gaze shifted to Shirley at the side.

The “vanish” the old scholar mentioned clearly referred to the “Celine” who had been with Shirley earlier—that “Celine” had finally turned into a tree.

“As for the exact rules of this ‘triggering’ and ‘vanishing,’ we may need several more tests to sum them up—or we may never be able to,” Morris went on as he put his blessed monocle back on. “But one point is clear. The appearance of ‘Celine’ is friendly toward us ‘Visitors,’ while it is hostile toward those cultists who intrude into the dreamwalking state. She called those intruders ‘filth.’ That should represent the Nameless One’s own judgment, or stance. That is good news for us.”

Duncan listened quietly to the old gentleman’s analysis and nodded. Then his gaze fell on Vanna.

“Then about that ‘giant,’ Vanna, what do you think?”

“I have no leads,” Vanna said after thinking for a while. She shook her head honestly. “I went over everything that ‘giant’ told me, but I couldn’t find

anything that matched in the myths or historical records of the Mortal Realm. Even in elven culture, where the historical line is relatively complete, there is no mention at all of that giant or of the ‘city of hills and plains’ he described…”

“Even the elves’ ‘heritage’ is only relatively complete. If that giant came from an age before the Great Annihilation, then it is perfectly normal that we cannot find matching clues in modern records,” Lucretia said, shaking her head. “The key question is what kind of relationship that giant and the desert under his feet have with the elves.”

The witch raised her head and looked into Vanna’s eyes.

“Miss Vanna, you never saw a trace of forest in that desert. And you didn’t hear any information about elves from the giant’s mouth either, did you?”

“Yes. Nothing at all,” Vanna answered with certainty.

“That elf called ‘Celine’ also had no idea what a desert even was. The only thing that could be linked to the ‘giant’ was her description of the creator Saslokar. She said Saslokar was a deity with no fixed form, able to turn into a deer, a goat, or a giant. But that connection seems far too forced to me,” Lucretia said as she thought aloud. “So right now, it feels like Vanna and the rest of us have been split into two different ‘space-times.’ The environments we face, the people we meet, and the information we hear are all completely different. Yet these two ‘space-times’ are definitely connected…”

“Yes. At the very least, both of these ‘space-times’ are certainly parts of the Nameless One’s dream,” Morris said at once, nodding. The old scholar wore a thoughtful look. After thinking for a moment, he spoke slowly: “Then we need to figure out one thing. What causes the huge difference between these two space-times? Is it a discontinuity in space, or a discontinuity in time?”

Chapter 599: The Mechanism of Awakening

As it turned out, what a truly seasoned scholar thought of when facing a problem was indeed different from an ordinary person.

The question Morris raised in his thinking almost instantly lit up many people's thoughts.

"First, we have a major premise. The 'desert' Vanna saw and the 'forest' the others saw are both parts of the Nameless One's dream. Under that premise, these two 'places' have only two possibilities," Morris said as he sat on the sofa, slowly laying out his thoughts. "Either the 'desert' and the 'forest' are different locations at the same moment in time, or they are the same location at different moments in time. In any case, they should not be two completely separate systems. At least one of time or space should connect them."

Nina did her best to follow the old gentleman's line of thought, then suddenly asked curiously: "Why can't they be both different locations and different moments in time?"

"Because they are in the same dream," Morris explained. "A single dream cannot contain two or more completely independent systems of time and space. Otherwise, they would be two unrelated dreams. At least, the knowledge I have right now does not support that idea."

"Oh…" Nina drew out the sound and nodded, half understanding and half not.

Duncan was still turning over the two possibilities Morris had raised. In his mind he kept testing the two models—“the same place at different moments” and “different places at the same moment”—against the clues they already knew. After a long while, he set the complicated question aside for now and said: “Let me remind you of something. Besides the ‘desert’ and the ‘forest,’ there is another ‘place’ drifting on the edge of the Mortal Realm. It is not inside the dream, but it is clearly also part of the Nameless One’s dream.”

“…That dark space filled with mist, where the Vanished’s reflection sails,” Morris said at once, his expression turning serious. “I have also been thinking about this. Which part of the Nameless One’s dream does that dark mist correspond to, exactly?

“The most likely guess for now is that it lies on the border of ‘about to wake but not yet awake.’ On that reflected Vanished, you can touch Atlantis’s echoes, but you cannot directly see what happens inside the dream. That matches the traits of a dream’s border very well. It is just that, clearly, the ‘border’ of the Nameless One’s dream is quite vast. It is large enough to let an entire ship drift aimlessly within it…”

Duncan recalled the streams of light he had seen on that reflected Vanished, and the voice from Atlantis he had heard within those lights. His expression slowly turned thoughtful.

The reflected Vanished was Goathead’s dream. It sailed along the border of Atlantis’s dream. Atlantis seemed to be waiting there all this time for Saslokar. Yet the Goathead in the dream had told Duncan that Saslokar was already dead, and had died long, long ago…

After thinking for a moment, Duncan shook his head. Right after that, he noticed something slightly off in the room, and his gaze landed on Lucretia: “Where is Rabby?”

“You finally noticed,” Lucretia said with a faint smile. “Rabby didn’t come back. It jumped into other dreams. It should still be chasing those prey right now.”

Duncan froze for a moment before he understood what Lucretia meant.

That eerie stuffed rabbit doll had actually tracked down those cultists?

“It will crawl out from those cultists’ nightmares and then leave coordinates in the Mortal Realm that are enough to summon you. I have already told Rabby to leave some of them alive,” Lucretia went on. “Don’t worry. In matters like that, it is reliable.”

Duncan nodded slowly.

Just then, he seemed to hear something again. His brow creased as he looked toward the nearby coffee table.

He reached out and gently brushed his hand across the surface of the table. Ghost?green flame spread over the wood like a phantom. The outline drawn by the fire took on a mirror-like sheen, and Agatha’s figure slowly emerged from within it.

“Agatha,” Duncan said as he looked at the lady appearing in the mirror. “Is something happening on the ship?”

“I may have found the reason the Nameless One’s dream jolted awake this time. It has to do with the First Mate,” Agatha said with a quick nod. “If possible, I hope you can come back for a bit.”

…

On the misty sea near Lightwind Harbor, a doorway of flame suddenly opened above the deck of the drifting Vanished. Duncan and Alice stepped out of the gate.

Duncan turned his head to glance at Alice, who had followed him back.

The doll had followed along as if it were only natural. When she saw Duncan looking her way, she just showed her trademark cheerful grin: “Hehe—I came along again!”

Duncan sighed helplessly and waved at the doll: “Fine. I’ll go to the captain’s cabin and see what’s going on. You go to the food storage hold again and check those barrels that had problems before.”

“Okay, Captain!”

Alice left in high spirits, as if she carried a great mission. Duncan watched the doll go, then tugged at the corner of his mouth and started toward the captain’s cabin.

As soon as he opened the door, he saw Goathead on the edge of the chart table whip its head around. Its black obsidian eyes stared straight at him. On the nearby wall, Agatha’s figure stood in the ancient oval scrying mirror. For some reason, this usually calm and reliable Gatekeeper looked utterly exhausted, even like she had lost all will to live.

Duncan froze for a moment when he saw Agatha’s deathly tired face. Before he could even ask what had happened, Goathead’s noisy voice suddenly burst out:

“Captain, you’re finally here! Your loyal—well, everything that needs saying—has been waiting so long! Is what Agatha said really true? Did that Nameless One’s dream appear again last night? And did you meet that Goathead who looks exactly like me again? She also said that eerie, gloomy Vanished you saw came out of my dream, but I didn’t even know I could dream! She said it was because of that little jolt of mine that the Nameless One’s dream was startled awake, and it even interrupted what you were doing. But I really don’t know what happened. You have to believe me, I never meant to hide anything, who could have known that last night would…”

In that instant, Duncan almost felt the buzzing racket condense into a solid wall and slam into him head-on. The nonstop chatter drilled into his ears with a roar, and his mind started to hum at once. Only after several minutes did he snap back to himself and quickly wave his hand: “Stop! Be quiet!”

Goathead stopped at once, but the joint between its neck and base gave a strange cracking sound—as if the earlier stream of chatter had been so strong that even slamming a halt to the topic made a noise.

Then Duncan heard a sigh of pure relief from the mirror beside him. Agatha said: “It’s finally over…”

Duncan gave the lady in the mirror a strange look.

“As you ordered, I did not hide what happened last night from the First Mate,” Agatha reported to the captain, her face full of exhaustion. “And then it turned into this. Before you came, it just kept going on and on at me. No matter where I hid, I could hear it muttering, muttering, muttering… Even the undead I met in the Frostholm cemetery—one who was framed, had his home destroyed, died unjustly, and clawed his way back out of the grave three days later from sheer resentment—couldn’t complain as much as it does! The noise it makes in one minute beats twenty old ladies at the citizen Center all complaining at once about the price of bread going up!”

Agatha added in deep bitter frustration: “And telling it to shut up doesn’t work at all! It only listens to you when you say that!”

Duncan finally understood why Agatha had worn that expression of “I might as well have died back in the Great Hollow under Frostholm” when he walked in.

It took a lot of effort for him to control his own expression. Keeping his face as straight as he could, he tried to comfort her: “…You’ve worked hard.”

Agatha let out a sigh. Her figure in the mirror split into several shards at once, showing that she had mentally cracked and no longer wanted to think or respond.

Duncan: “…”

He felt that he probably shouldn’t have stuffed so many strange ideas into his crew members’ heads. When they tried to carry out some abstract phrasing, they ended up even more abstract than the words themselves.

Ignoring the cracked Agatha in the mirror, Duncan turned his gaze back to Goathead.

The black wooden carving was staring straight at him. Maybe because it had been holding back so many words, even its stiff wooden face looked a little twisted.

“Don’t waste too many words,” Duncan said first, making that point clear. Then he spoke again, his face serious: “Second, everything Agatha said is true.”

Goathead’s head twitched. Its jaw opened and closed several times before it finally forced out the words: “I… I really, in my sleep, turned the Vanished’s reflection into that ship you saw in that dark space?”

“Or to put it another way,” Duncan said calmly, meeting Goathead’s eyes with a godlike gaze, “when the veil of night descends over Lightwind Harbor, your dream will sail along the border of the Nameless One’s dream.”

Goathead’s head squeaked and creaked as it shook. It looked oddly conflicted: “But I really don’t know… I was just steering while fully awake. The enchanted sea chart also recorded the Vanished’s cruising route, and it matches my memory exactly…”

Agatha’s voice suddenly came from the side: “Then how do you explain that little jolt of yours when dawn came?”

Goathead fell silent.

Duncan, however, raised his head and looked at the oval scrying mirror on the wall.

Agatha, who had been in pieces just a moment ago, had already recovered and was now watching them with a very serious expression.

“After leaving the Nameless One’s dream, I returned here at once,” Agatha said. “I saw the First Mate wake up from some kind of… trance. It said it had just been distracted, but I can be sure that the Vanished’s reflection returned to normal at the very moment it ‘woke up.’ If I’m not mistaken, that should also be the reason the Nameless One’s dream was jolted awake this time.

“So I suspect that whether it is Atlantis or the First Mate, as long as one of them wakes up, the Nameless One’s dream will end.”

Chapter 600: Traces After Waking

Agatha could slip through shadows and mirrors in an instant. In the very first moment after the Nameless One's dream ended, she could return to the Vanished in the Mortal Realm and observe the changes at the border of the reflection. Duncan did not doubt her ability at all.

"As long as either Atlantis or Goathead wakes up in a jolt, the Nameless One's dream will end…" Duncan frowned slightly and thought carefully about the idea Agatha had just raised. "So that means the Nameless One's dream is actually being 'sustained' by Atlantis and Goathead together?"

"Or rather, it is their shared dream," Agatha said seriously. "That would also explain why that 'reflected Vanished' was sailing along the edge of Atlantis's dream."

Duncan did not speak for a while. He just quietly sorted through his thoughts.

After a long time, he suddenly broke the silence: "So, like you said, the reason the Nameless One's dream ended early this time was that my First Mate was startled awake. – Then what startled him awake in the first place?"

Agatha thought for a moment, then spoke, not very sure: "Maybe… it had something to do with the way you steered at the end?"

"Steered?" Duncan's brows tightened a little.

“You were very careful with your flames this time. You even planted your fire in advance into the Vanished’s reflection, leaving a safe Fire Seed on that ‘ship in the dream.’ That did keep Atlantis from being ‘frightened,’ but to that dream ship, you yourself were still an ‘outsider’,” Agatha said as she laid out her guess. “Do you remember? You forced your way into that dark, foggy space from the ‘outside’ by touching that vine in Lightwind Harbor in the Mortal Realm…”

Agatha spoke while Duncan listened. Goathead kept turning his head, looking at the captain and then at Agatha. As the most direct party involved in the whole affair, he was also the most confused one on the spot. But now he finally understood what Agatha meant. He reacted at once and hurriedly looked at Duncan: “Captain, my loyalty is beyond doubt, Captain! You are the true Master of the Vanished. Even if I really was dreaming, I would still…”

“I know, but the problem isn’t you,” Duncan cut Goathead off with a wave of his hand. “It’s a basic property of the dream – it rejects ‘intrusions.’”

He paused, then continued while he thought: “It seems that unless you are dragged directly into the inner Dreamwalking space like Vanna and the others, and become part of the Nameless One’s dream, any attempt to connect to the Nameless One’s dream from the outside will cause this kind of ‘rejection.’ It will either wake Atlantis, or wake you…”

Goathead lifted his head. Even his hard wooden face showed a strangely human, conflicted look. “Then what do we do? Captain, you know I don’t even know when I’m dreaming. I can’t control this at all…”

“You can’t control it, but this matter itself may not be that hard,” Duncan said thoughtfully. “I already have an idea… maybe I can test it tonight.”

…

Lucretia frowned as she watched Taran Ael busy himself among a huge pile of “junk” in the laboratory. After a long time, she finally could not help speaking: “You sent an apprentice to my house early in the morning to drag me here, just so I could see how messy your lab is? You’ve been ‘digging’ in that pile of tangled machines and papers for half an hour… Did I ever tell you I’m very busy?”

“Almost done, almost done. There’s a huge pile of data that was recorded automatically. I need to sort it all together…” Taran Ael lifted his head from behind a machine with a black casing. There was some unknown grease smeared into his messy hair. “I improved all this equipment myself. Now it seems there is still a lot of room for them to be more convenient… Oh, I finally got this paper box off. This is the last one…”

The elven Grand Scholar muttered as he finally squeezed out from that dizzying forest of devices. He came back to Lucretia with a big armful of printouts, paper tapes, and film. He put everything on the table and, without even lifting his head, went on: “Yes, I know you’re busy, because Lightwind Harbor is shrouded in a massive manifestation, and you and your Father are running everywhere because of it. I’m grateful for that. But we ‘locals’ should also do something, even if we still haven’t found a way to fight that ‘dream’…”

Lucretia’s expression finally grew a little more serious. She put aside her annoyance at having her work broken off and being rushed out so early. She came to the Grand Scholar’s desk and looked at the records spread across it. “So, this is your effort to fight that ‘dream’?”

“I’m not the only one working hard. Many departments, many of my colleagues, and other organizations in the city, the Knowledge Guard and the constables – we’re all trying to find a way. We may not be as strong as your Father, but clumsy methods are still methods… Yes, this part is my result.”

As Taran Ael spoke, he pulled out a long strip of paper tape from the pile and laid it in front of Lucretia.

“This is last night’s record of my vital signs and sleep.”

Lucretia’s expression changed slightly. She took the paper tape from him and looked seriously at the jumping curves and rows of punched marks on it. She noticed it was automatic data output from some kind of punch-card recorder, and there were very obvious “breaks” in the data.

“I slept here in the lab last night,” Taran Ael said as he pointed to a cot in the corner of the room. Several strange devices sat beside the cot. They looked as if they had been moved here in a hurry, their cables and pipes tangled together. “I made all this stuff before. I tried to use it to improve my sleep efficiency, to get better rest with the shortest possible sleep time… Those electrodes can record my brain activity. The curves on the tape are that. The punches next to them are my breathing records: one round hole for each breath out, one square hole for each breath in…”

“There are two clear interruptions here,” Lucretia cut him off. “Judging from the timestamps on the edge of the tape, they happened at nine o’clock last night and early this morning, which means…”

“Which means the start and end of the Nameless One’s dream,” Taran Ael took the tape back from her, found the two breaks, and held the tape up before him. “At those two times, my brain clearly had a ‘blank.’ But that’s not the biggest problem. The biggest problem is actually… between those two breaks.”

He held up the tape. On that long record, the curves and punched holes ran on in a continuous line.

“There are still records,” he pointed to the section between nine last night and this morning. “Do you see the problem, Lady Lucretia…?”

“I’m guessing you recorded more than just this,” Lucretia already understood. She spoke quickly. “Where are the other things?”

“This is the most direct one.” Taran Ael did not try to be mysterious. He turned, picked up another stack from the table – a pile of black-and-white images.

Lucretia took the stack and glanced at it. They were all photographs. The subject was the cot in the corner of the lab.

The first few photos showed Taran Ael lying on the bed. In one of them, the Grand Scholar even waved at the camera. But in the later photos, there was only an empty bed – the electrodes that had been fixed to the Grand Scholar’s head had fallen onto the pillow.

“I set up three cameras, hooked them up to timers and continuous film. Every fifteen minutes, they each took one picture of where I sleep, from three angles,” Taran Ael said. “You see? After nine o’clock, there’s no one on the bed – because that’s when the Nameless One’s dream arrived, and I had already vanished to ‘the other side’…”

The Grand Scholar spoke as he picked up the long paper tape again. He found the middle section and placed it in front of the Sea Witch.

“So here’s the question, my lady – between nine last night and five this morning, in the time when I had already vanished from the Mortal Realm, whose brain activity did this machine record?”

Lucretia drew in a slow breath and looked at the last photo in her hand.

In the empty cot in the corner of the lab, the electrodes used to read brain activity lay loosely on the pillow. The metal plates of the electrodes gleamed coldly in the lens, as if, in the silent veil of night over the whole city, they were quietly connected to ghosts unseen by the naked eye.

“The problem doesn’t end there. The Nameless One’s dream has brought us many puzzles. The strange data recorded by these devices is only one part of it,” Taran Ael’s voice pulled Lucretia out of her thoughts. The Grand Scholar walked back behind his desk, sat down, and slowly said, “The other problem is this – after Dreamwalking, where did we actually go?”

“…What do you mean?”

“I just listened to your description. When the Nameless One’s dream came, you and your Father’s followers were drawn into a strange dream. There was a vast forest in it, very similar to what I saw when I was trapped in the dream before. But… I have no memory of anything like that from last night.

“Ever since I was trapped in that dream the last time, and you pulled me out, I have never seen that forest again in my sleep.

“And it’s not only me. Everyone in this city is the same. When the Nameless One’s dream descends, everyone in the city disappears into the veil of night. But we don’t wake up in a world of dreams like you. We don’t act in that mysterious forest. We close our eyes, and when we open them again, everything is a normal new day. If you and your Father didn’t tell us, we wouldn’t even notice anything happened last night.

“So where did everyone in the city go when the veil of night descended?”

Lucretia of course did not know the answer. Taran Ael did not really expect to get an answer from this witch either. He was just talking to himself, giving himself a goal.

sunlight came through the clouds, through a tall tree outside the lab, through its thick canopy and crisscrossing branches and leaves. It scattered in mottled patches across the Grand Scholar’s desk and across the data recorded by his automatic devices.

Lucretia slowly raised her head. Her gaze followed the sunlight as she looked at the flickering shadows of leaves outside the window. Her eyes slowly widened.

“Master Taran Ael…”

“What is it, my lady?”

“…Did you always have a tree like that outside your lab?”

Chapter 601: The Growing Dream of the Nameless One

It was as if Taran Ael only became aware of what was wrong with the surroundings when Lucretia spoke. He turned his head to the window in shock. He stared for a long time at the lush tree that blocked most of the sunlight outside, then his expression changed. He quickly walked to the window.

He stood there and looked out at the tree. Doubt showed on his face. It seemed he still could not tell whether his memory or the world of the Mortal Realm in front of him was wrong. After a moment, he finally reacted and shook his head at once. “No. There was no such tree.”

The Grand Scholar spoke and pointed toward the roof of the building opposite the tree. “Remember when the Sun went out? I jumped out of this window and landed on that roof across the way. There was definitely no tree in the way then.”

Lucretia also came to the window and looked down at the base of the tree. She saw it rooted in one corner of the yard. Its position looked especially abrupt. Yet part of its roots pushed out of the soil and merged into the nearby steps and paving, as if it had been growing there for many years.

She turned back and saw the grave look on Taran Ael’s face.

“The Nameless One’s dream is still growing, my lady,” the Grand Scholar broke the silence. His tone was serious and low. “Some of its parts have already spread into the Mortal Realm in broad daylight.”

“Not just spreading, Master,” Lucretia reminded him. “If I hadn’t called your attention to it, you still wouldn’t have noticed anything strange about this tree. And even I only realized something was wrong after quite a long time. Remember? It was already there when I walked into this room.”

Taran Ael said nothing. He just looked out the window with a heavy expression. He watched the nameless tree that had taken root in the Mortal Realm, the streets and roofs beyond it, and all the parts of the city he could see.

“It’s very hard for people to notice how strange a dream is while they’re inside it… The subconscious will rationalize everything bizarre in the dream, to keep us from being scared to death by our own dreams,” the Grand Scholar finally turned back after a long silence. “The boundary between the Mortal Realm and the dream is blurring, my lady. Maybe before long, the whole of Lightwind Harbor will never wake up again. No one knows whether the city will still exist then, or in what form… We have to stop the Nameless One’s dream from growing any further.”

“Take your notes and your clear head, sort out your thoughts, and go find Governor Sara Mell. He needs help right now,” Lucretia said. “You should also go see Ted. That Truth Keeper is probably at his wits’ end too.”

“I’ll set out right away,” Taran Ael said at once. But then he could not help glancing at Lucretia. “…And you?”

This “witch” did not belong to Lightwind Harbor, but she had clearly stepped into this matter already. From what Taran Ael knew of Lucretia, she would never just stand aside at a key moment.

“I have no fewer things to do than you,” Lucretia waved her hand. The edges of her figure were already starting to blur. “The Nameless One’s dream will definitely appear again. I have to prepare for tonight – and my eyes are not only on Lightwind Harbor.”

Before Taran Ael could respond, the Witch's figure suddenly burst into a flurry of colorful paper. The paper swirled up in a sudden whirlwind and flew out of the room.

In the Harbor district, on the upper deck of the Radiant Star moored by the shore, those flying scraps of colored paper spun into the cabin and came together again as the Sea Witch's figure.

A tin sailor pieced together from scrap iron plates, bolts, and water pipes hurried up to her. Its steps creaked and squeaked as it bowed to the captain. "Mistress, Mr. Tyrian was looking for you. A call came an hour ago."

"I know. I felt it," Lucretia said quickly. "Go find a few helpers. Move all the camera apparatus from the warehouse up onto the deck and aim them at the docks of Lightwind Harbor. Set the timers. After nine o'clock tonight, record the changes in Lightwind Harbor. Go."

The tin sailor bent at once. "Yes, Mistress."

The rusty sailor left. Its squeaking footsteps faded into the distance. Lucretia frowned slightly at its retreating back and muttered under her breath: "You need oil…"

Then she shook her head, stepped to the scrying crystal, and raised her hand to light it.

After a short wait, Tyrian's figure appeared inside the scrying crystal.

"Looks like you're busy over there too," Tyrian spoke as soon as he saw her. "Is the situation in Lightwind Harbor still getting worse?"

"Today I saw a tree outside Taran Ael's lab. A tree that has 'grown' from the dream into the Mortal Realm," Lucretia said calmly. "The city is slowly falling into the Nameless One's dream. Or the Nameless One's dream is slowly surfacing from the Mortal Realm. Either way, things really are

getting worse here. But tell me about your side first. You sent word so early. It seems what I was worried about has still happened."

"In the elves' residential quarter near Cemetery No. 2, there have been three reported cases of 'Sleep Sickness,'" Tyrian did not bother to build suspense. "Three elves have fallen into a sleep they can't wake from, and no other illness can be found. Their condition is very close to that Sleep Sickness case you mentioned before in the city of Pland. But this time, the psychiatrist's hypnosis and dream-intervention methods are all useless."

"hypnosis and dream intervention are useless…"

"Yes. According to the psychiatrist's report, the three elves look very much like 'the Dreamless' – you should know that special 'congenital defect' among elves," Tyrian nodded. "The psychiatrist simply can't find any entrance to the three patients' dreams. It's as if their minds have fallen into endless nothingness and already vanished from the Mortal Realm. If all methods of waking them fail, we can only rely on drip-feeding nutrients to keep their vital signs going."

Lucretia's brows slowly drew together. She stayed silent in thought.

Tyrian's voice went on: "I'm not worried about the situation right now. Three unconscious patients are not enough to put real pressure on the city. What I fear is what happens next. Frostholm is on the northern border, and elves have always liked borderlands. There are thousands of elves registered in this city, spread across all the districts. If this 'sleep' spreads quickly, the order that Frostholm finally managed to stabilize will face another shock."

"I know. But you'd better prepare yourself," Lucretia finally spoke. "Dad is trying to find the source of the Nameless One's dream, but that will take time. From what you've said, the reach of this dream is not even limited to Lightwind Harbor. It acts directly on the race called 'elves'… Some clues

show it points to the elves' original faith and involves a god. You know how troublesome that is."

The corner of Tyrian's mouth twitched. After a few seconds of silence, he said very carefully: "If – and I mean if – in the worst case you really have to face an Elder God in a runaway state over there, not one of the Sun's spawn, not some replica in the Deep Sea, but a deity trapped in a race's memory… do you think Father…"

Lucretia knew what her elder brother wanted to say.

They had not worried about their Father for many years – or rather, they used to worry, but in a completely different way.

After several seconds, Lucretia finally let out a light breath. "I'll shout 'Come on!' for him, then stand far away and watch."

Tyrian: "…"

"What else should I do?" Lucretia glanced at her elder brother in the scrying crystal. "Rush up there like you and get smacked by Dad in passing? How many poisonous mushrooms would I have to eat before I went to meddle in a battle at that level?"

Tyrian's expression turned very awkward. "…I know. But can you stop bringing up how Father smacked me…"

"Then I'll bring up how you got caught by Dad watching that exotic dance."

"…Let's change the topic."

Lucretia casually ended the connection.

The Sea Witch had a pleased look on her face.

Her elder brother still looked quite energetic. That was good.

She sat in front of the scrying crystal for a while and sorted out her thoughts. Then she raised her hand and tapped on the surface of the crystal again.

“Rabby, I know you’re listening.”

A faint light stirred deep inside the scrying crystal. A moment later, Rabby’s sharp, girlish voice came from within the sphere: “Mistress~ shhh~ Rabby is moving in secret right now…”

“Looks like you’ve already found where they’re hiding,” Lucretia said quietly. “Can you tell which city it is?”

“Doesn’t really look like a city,” the light inside the scrying crystal slowly brightened and dimmed as Rabby spoke in a pleased tone. “Looking through their memories, it feels more like a ship…”

“A ship?”

“Mm~ these cultists built a ship,” Rabby said proudly, dragging out her words on purpose in a rhythm that made people want to punch something. “They built a ship, and there’s blood e~very~where~~!”

Lucretia froze for a moment. She ignored Rabby’s deliberately annoying tone. Instead, a look of pleasant surprise slowly appeared on her face.

Rabby had found one of the cultists’ sea bases.

…

Waves slammed against the hull outside the cabin. Steam pipes hissed through relief valves in the bulkheads. From the direction of the engine room came a harsh, irritating noise. A thin man sat up from his bed. His gloomy mood made his already sinister face grow even darker.

He sat on the edge of the bed in a daze for a while, then casually picked up the cup by his side and drained it in one gulp.

Last night’s operation had not gone smoothly. Their careful plan had been broken by a sudden accident. The girl who had acted together with the hound from the Abyssal Deep had suddenly burst out with a terrible, strange power from within her body and destroyed those Remnant Folk of the Sun in an instant. That was beyond anything anyone had imagined.

The choking terror brought by those wildly spreading flames still clung to the hearts of every Church comrade who had been near the scene.

The gloomy man let out a sigh, put down the cup, and rose from the bed.

Resting in his room all morning had not eased the pressure. Maybe he should go see how the others were doing.

He shook his head, cleared his thoughts while standing by the bed, then turned and walked toward the door.

But just then, something caught the corner of his eye. His steps stopped without him thinking.

He bent down and looked at the soft white mass at the foot of the bed –

“Cotton?”

Chapter 602: A Master Angler’s Awareness

Knock, knock, knock.

The sudden knocking at the door cut off the sinister man’s brief confusion when he saw that wad of cotton. He quickly drew back his gaze and turned toward the sound.

After sensing the aura at the door for a moment, he walked over and undid the padlock.

A man in a dark hooded robe stood at the door. Half his face hid in the shadows of the hood. He seemed displeased at how slowly the door had opened and asked: “Why did you take so long to open the door?”

“I am not your servant, Dumont,” the sinister man in the room said, frowning, clearly in a bad mood. “Do not take the Saint’s momentary favor too seriously.”

“Think what you like, Richard. I am only reminding you,” the Annihilator called Dumont said calmly. “Do not let fear linger in your heart for too long. You have been off ever since you pulled out of the Nameless One’s dream two days ago. Your extra caution, fear, slowness, and suspicion have already drawn the Saint’s attention. He has not shown displeasure yet, but if you stay this way, it will harm our cause…”

Before Dumont finished, the Annihilator named Richard stepped forward in a sudden move. His sinister face was almost pressed against the other man’s

hood as he snapped: “You could always go in and try it yourself, instead of staying safe here in the Mortal Realm and making snide remarks!”

“I will go,” Dumont said with the same calm expression. He did not mind Richard’s hostility at all. He only took half a step back and said: “Tonight, as one of the next batch of Chosen, I will enter the Nameless One’s dream with you.”

Richard finally drew back his hostile look. He stared at Dumont in surprise and asked: “The Saint has already decided to send another group? The plan moved up?”

“What else did you expect?” Dumont spread his hands and shook his head. “What you reported has been taken very seriously. Now the Saint knows that a dangerous power hostile to us has appeared inside the Nameless One’s dream, that another faction has begun to move. Our ‘allies’ also sent word. They seem to have already fought this enemy.

“So put away your complaints and your paranoia. I know you ran into trouble in the last operation, but you are among your own. The Holy Lord’s divine blessing is upon us.”

“…The Holy Lord’s divine blessing is upon us,” Richard finally let out a quiet breath. The anger faded from his face. “I was a bit worked up just now.”

“That is understandable. After all, you were hurt in the operation before last, and in your last operation you ran into danger again. These wounds are a heavy burden on the mind,” Dumont said. He glanced over Richard’s shoulder.

Faint dust floated in the air. A translucent black chain hung in midair, and at the end of the chain, a Death-Omen Bird perched weakly on a nearby cabinet, clearly in poor shape.

“So you are sure you do not need a few more days of rest?” Dumont asked. “In your current state, even if you skip one operation, no one will complain.”

“No need,” Richard said at once, shaking his head. His eyes grew wary again. “My devotion to the Holy Lord is my greatest strength. I will have myself ready before tonight.”

“…Since you are that determined, I will pass it on to the Saint,” Dumont said with a nod. “Also, since you are not going to miss tonight’s operation, get ready. Before nightfall, go to the assembly hall. The Saint will announce some things.”

Richard met Dumont’s eyes for a moment, then nodded: “All right.”

Dumont said nothing more. He stepped back again and silently watched the door close. Only then did a faint smile appear on his always calm, indifferent face. He turned and walked deeper into the corridor of the ship.

Another hooded Annihilator, short and stocky, stepped out of the shadows at the corner of the corridor and walked alongside Dumont.

After they had gone a short distance, the cultist named Dumont finally broke the silence and said: “Richard is not in good shape. His demons are weakening, and his mind is losing its balance. Soon, the symbiotic pact will drag him into death. Fate is closing in on this fellow.”

“That is the fate he chose. The Abyssal Deep will remember his sacrifice,” the other cultist said quietly. “We will all return to that place of origin in the end. It is only a question of sooner or later… But I am really curious. Why is his mental imbalance so serious? The others who entered the Nameless One’s dream also ran into all kinds of failures. Some were even badly wounded by corruption and pulled out of the dream on the verge of death, yet their mental state is not nearly this bad…”

Dumont stopped and glanced back at the distant closed door.

After a moment, he looked away and shook his head: “Not all serious wounds are the same.”

He turned again and kept walking, speaking at an easy pace: “If you are badly hurt fighting corruption in the dream and come back from the edge of death, all you need afterward is rest and honor. But if you are beaten half to death in the dream by an underage maiden using a dog, then wake up screaming and fall out of bed—in the assembly hall, no less, with the Saint reading your memory on the spot—then you are going to need more than rest.”

When he finished, both Annihilators fell silent at the same time. They walked on slowly for a while. At last the short, stocky cultist muttered under his breath: “That is really terrifying…”

“…Yes, terrifying indeed.”

Inside the cabin, Richard sat on the bed with a dark expression, listening as the sound from the corridor faded. His face grew more twisted with every passing second.

His symbiotic pact demon, the Death-Omen Bird, lay weakly on the low cabinet beside him. Thin mist rose from the bird-shaped demon, floating in the air like a real substance and spreading in all directions, boosting its master’s senses.

But after a while, he forced down the urge to keep extending his senses. With an effort of reason, he drew back the Death-Omen Bird’s power.

He had to restore himself and his contracted demon as fast as possible. He had to prove himself in the next operation. The cycling End was drawing near. This world’s dusk would soon arrive. Whether the followers of the

Abyssal Deep could win a place in the unknown age after the era of the Deep Sea would depend on what they did in that “dream.”

Proving himself in that “dream” would be the best shortcut toward eternal glory.

He let out a long breath, but his hand brushed against something soft on the bed.

It was that wad of cotton again.

Richard picked it up, puzzled, and looked around the not-so-spacious cabin, as if he were searching for where this strange cotton had come from.

Did it escape from the bedding?

He searched the room, but could not find any source of more cotton. In the end he went to the window and scratched his hair in confusion.

Why did he care so much about a wad of cotton?

The Annihilator hesitated for a moment, then shrugged. Forget it. It was only a wad of cotton. It was not worth thinking about.

He pulled open his shirt and felt along his skin until he found a zipper. He tugged it open and stuffed the cotton into the writhing flesh beneath.

A soft laugh suddenly came from the corner of the room, like a five-or six-year-old girl hiding in the wardrobe, watching her clumsy lord and giggling at him.

The Death-Omen Bird on the cabinet seemed to sense something. It lifted its head and looked in puzzlement toward the sound, then lowered its head again.

…

“Rabby found one of those cultists’ strongholds?”

In the captain’s cabin of the Radiant Star, Lucretia sat at her dressing table. ghostly green flame danced along the edge of the mirror. Candles burned quietly before the glass, and her father’s voice came from within it.

“Yes,” Lucretia nodded toward the mirror. “The stronghold is on a ship. And from the looks of it, they are not just ‘hiding’ on that ship. They have full control of a large vessel, and there are many Annihilators gathered on board. It must be an important base.”

“…That rabbit has done great work,” Duncan said in the mirror, his expression grave, his tone full of feeling. “Those cultists come and go like ghosts. They never act openly in the city-states, and they are very hard to catch. I did not expect that we would find one of their gathering points this time… Hiding on a ship really was beyond our expectations.”

“The ship is large, and it looks like it was built for dark and bloody rituals,” Lucretia said. “Rabby smelled a thick scent of blood on board, the lingering smell of many sacrificial rites. A ship like that cannot dock at a city-state like an ordinary vessel. The aura left by dark rituals cannot fool the church, so there must be a supply port behind it…”

As Lucretia laid out her thoughts, Duncan in the mirror fell into deep thought. After a while, he suddenly asked: “Is Rabby still hidden on the ship? Will it be discovered?”

“It is very good at hiding. Unless it goes out of its way to face some of the higher-ranking cultists head-on, like that ‘Saint,’ it will not be exposed under normal conditions,” Lucretia said. “It comes from the Shadows of the Spirit Realm and can hide in people’s emotions and senses. On that ship, the entire place is full of negative aura. That environment itself is its best cover.”

“Good,” Duncan nodded. “Let Rabby keep hiding. Do not let it contact that ‘Saint.’ Have it gather as much information as possible.”

His original plan had been to have Rabby build a mirror ritual as soon as it found the cultists' hideout so that he could "descend" to the scene in person. Then, before those cultists all died, he would rush to teleport his followers over, then beat those cultists up. Before their symbiotic pact demons could kill themselves, he would keep knocking them out and see how many he could capture in the end.

The whole plan was simple and efficient, and Vanna had strongly approved it.

But now it seemed that the "big fish" Rabby had found was even bigger than anyone had expected. Naturally, he could not solve the problem in such a simple and rough way.

As a master angler, he had to let the line out a little farther.

Chapter 603: Test

Lucretia fully agreed with Duncan's idea of "letting the line out to catch a big fish." In fact, from the start she had not been very keen on the simple, rough plan that Father and Vanna had come up with.

It was not that she had any grudge against the Athlete. Mainly, she felt that with how sensitive and afraid Dog was of the spirit flame, and how quickly Abyssal demons killed themselves, they might not catch a single living cultist if they really used such a crude approach…

"Those cultists will hold a gathering before nightfall. I will have Rabby find a way to get some information," Lucretia said as she thought aloud. "Right now, the biggest problem is that there is a so-called 'Saint' on that ship. That means Rabby can only 'observe.' Any active move could be noticed by that Saint."

"A Saint?" Duncan sounded curious. "I know about the Saints of the Four Gods. I have a high opinion of Vanna's fighting ability. But what is the deal with the Oblivion Church's Saints?"

His question made sense. The Saints of the Four Gods were people favored by their deities. Their main trait was not great fighting power—though most Saints could fight—but their ability to communicate with their gods. Ordinary priests needed very complex rituals and certain prices to pay before they could hear a few whispers from their deities. Saints, on the other hand, almost needed no preparation. Sometimes a prayer in their heart was enough to let them talk with their gods. In more extreme cases, if a

Saint was in danger, their deity would even find a way to contact them first, to give warning or guidance.

Put simply, the gods pampered them like their own children.

But the Annihilators' "Saints" could not be like that at all. Duncan knew well the state of the Abyssal Lord and the Lord's attitude toward those so-called "followers." From that one line—"catch a few Annihilators and see what happens"—Duncan was sure of one thing. If one of those cultists ever became a "Saint" who could truly hear their god's will, they would probably be "called home" the very day they were promoted—and then dragged into the Deep Sea of the Abyssal Deep by their "Lord" and beaten again and again.

"Annihilators see Abyssal demons as the purest beings, the ones closest to the original Blueprint, so they keep using demonic power to change themselves and get closer to that Blueprint. In this process, they gain greater power," Lucretia explained. "I heard Vanna talk about this. In Frostholm, she once saw high-ranking Oblivion priests who had almost fused with Abyssal demons through symbiotic pacts. And the so-called 'Saints' go a step further.

"There is not much human left in them. They look more like demons than humans. They move like Abyssal demons and can draw power straight from the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea. Aside from keeping a human way of thinking, they are basically a kind of 'Abyssal Deep creature.' These Oblivion 'Saints' are almost able to enter the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea as freely as demons do—that so-called 'eternal paradise.' Perhaps it is only the last bit of humanity in them that still chains them to the Mortal Realm.

"Annihilators have no true deity watching over them, but through contracts with demons, they can still gain great power. Their 'Saints' are the same.

Those freaks are powerful, strong-willed, and know countless forbidden truths about corruption. If they faced each other head-on… Rabby would not be a match for those Saints."

Duncan listened with interest to Lucretia's "little-known trivia," then suddenly asked: "So how do they compare with Vanna?"

Lucretia froze, her expression turning a bit odd as she thought it over.

After a long pause, she finally said: "…Miss Vanna's fighting power is quite… 'special' even among Saints. I think it is hard to compare."

Duncan nodded in understanding: "All right, I see."

After a brief pause, Lucretia spoke again: "There are some other developments."

Duncan's voice came from the mirror: "Go on."

Lucretia organized her words: "Tyrian sent a message. Three cases of 'Sleep Sickness' have appeared in the city-state of Frostholm. The patients are Elves. Their symptoms are close to…"

She had only spoken half a sentence when the voice from the mirror cut in: "The same kind of coma as that Elf maiden Flora from Pland and as Taran Ael back then, right? But this time, hypnosis and dreamwalking by psychiatrists have both failed. Their dreams are like empty holes, and their minds are lost inside those holes."

Lucretia stared at the mirror in surprise: "How did you… the message from Pland?!"

Then she suddenly understood.

"Right before I contacted you," Duncan nodded in the mirror, "Heidi reported four such patients. They are also Elves, also in an endless sleep. And if things are as I suspect, these are not the only two city-states with

problems. Maybe tomorrow, maybe even later today, similar reports will reach Lightwind Harbor from other city-states."

Lucretia frowned and listened. After a long moment, she blinked, remembering the ancient tales Taran Ael had once told. She murmured as if to herself: "All Elves… are the fruit and seeds of Atlantis…"

"Legends are the projection of the Mortal Realm. Some parts of those stories are true," Duncan said slowly. "Atlantis's power holds the Elf race together. It gives them a hive-like bond. On the level of the spirit, it is possible that all Elves are one whole.

"This trait has lain dormant for a long time, but now… the Nameless One's dream has awakened their link."

"Hive… one whole in spirit…" Lucretia repeated Duncan's words without thinking. The description made her frown, but she could not find any phrase more fitting. "So the Nameless One's dream is spreading among the Elves, and Lightwind Harbor was only the first place where it broke out?"

"I call it the 'Primordial Blast Point,' the very first point of outbreak," Duncan said softly. "And now the question is—why did this place become the Primordial Blast Point? What caused the Nameless One's dream to erupt?"

Why?

Lucretia blinked in shock. While she was still dazed, Duncan's voice continued from the mirror:

"Before the Nameless One's dream broke out, two things happened. First, the Sun went out. The whole Boundless Sea fell into darkness. Apart from Pland, Frostholm, and Lightwind Harbor, every other city-state lost twelve hours of time. Second… the Vanished crossed the 'vanished sea' and came to the waters near Lightwind Harbor."

Lucretia understood what Father meant at once.

She spoke without thinking: “So the Sun’s extinction activated the Nameless One’s dream hidden in the Elf race, and the approach of the Vanished… made Lightwind Harbor the ‘Primordial Blast Point’…”

“The first part was my guess from the start,” Duncan said with a nod. “The second part is a possibility that only just occurred to me.”

Lucretia thought for a moment, and a bold idea popped into her mind: “Then if the Vanished moves away from Lightwind Harbor now, will that temporarily hold back the spread of the Nameless One’s dream?”

“The Vanished is already moving away.”

In the captain’s cabin of the Vanished, Duncan turned his head and looked out the window.

Chaotic, dim clouds covered the sky. The black sea rose and fell silently in the distance. Mist lay over everything. The world held only black and white. Countless twisted, bizarre, half-real shadows flickered in and out within the fog far away, always keeping their distance.

“The Vanished is sailing at full speed in the depths of the Spirit Realm, heading north away from Lightwind Harbor,” Duncan said. “Next I will run a series of tests. They will include moving the Vanished to different places, sinking deeper into the Spirit Realm, and turning the whole ship into spirit form, to see what effect these changes have on the Nameless One’s dream.”

As he spoke, Duncan pulled his gaze back from the window and looked at the mirror beside him.

“But I doubt such actions can stop the Nameless One’s dream from growing. From the messages coming from the city-states so far, this ‘dream’ ignores the barriers of space and acts directly on every Elf. The Sun’s extinction and the Vanished’s activity are only the first ‘triggers,’ not

the power that keeps the dream going. What truly sustains this dream is the Elf race itself.

“Still, I will try a few things with Goathead, to see whether changes to him can affect the Nameless One’s dream. Many clues now point in that direction. My current First Mate is that ancient creation deity from Elf legend.”

Lucretia looked surprised in the mirror: “But did you not say that the Goathead on the reflected Vanished told you Saslokar died a long time ago?”

“Is a deity’s ‘life’ and ‘death’ really that simple?” Duncan shook his head slightly. “Even if we do not talk about deities, on the Vanished alone I am not short of people who have ‘died before.’”

Lucretia opened her mouth, but found she had no good way to comment on Father’s followers. In the end she could only change the subject a bit stiffly: “Then what about Lightwind Harbor…”

“My true body will move away from the city for now with the Vanished,” Duncan said. “That is necessary for the tests I have planned. But Vanna and Morris will stay in the city. They will keep watching the Nameless One’s dream. For the time being, I cannot come back easily, but my power can still pass into the city through mirrors. If you run into trouble, you can call me at any time.”

Lucretia nodded. After a few seconds of silence, she spoke again with some hesitation: “When you are far away, you have to use your own avatar form to set up a beacon so that AI can use teleportation, right?”

Duncan glanced at Lucretia in the mirror and nodded: “…Yes. Is there a problem?”

“This… seems a bit inconvenient,” Lucretia said carefully. “When the Vanished was near Lightwind Harbor, you and your followers could travel between the city and the ship at any time. Now that you have to move away from the city, you can only send power through mirrors. Have you ever thought about… stationing an avatar form in Lightwind Harbor?”

Duncan stayed silent for two or three seconds, then shook his head with a serious face: “I do not plan to—for now. You know what my avatar forms need as ‘raw material.’ Unless I happen to run into a fitting situation, I do not intend to create another avatar form.”

Though her suggestion had been refused, Lucretia seemed to relax in the mirror: “All right, Dad.”

Chapter 604: Duncan’s Way of Solving the Problem

The image in the mirror slowly faded, but Duncan still stood in front of it and stayed deep in thought for a long time.

He had never hidden his situation with his avatar form from Lucretia, nor had he concealed the powers linked to those avatar forms. His messenger Ai could move quickly between the beacons formed by his avatar forms, and his power and main consciousness could switch between avatar forms in an instant. This ability was powerful and convenient, but in Lightwind Harbor he had not arranged any such avatar form.

One reason, of course, was that he really had not found a “suitable” vessel. But he had not told anyone the more important reason.

He looked at the mirror in front of him and studied the face he now wore.

He did not know when it had begun, but he had already become completely used to this face that had once been so strange, this powerful body, this stern and gloomy look. It had become the “name” under which he lived in this world.

A soul named Zhou Ming occupied this shell, just as it occupied the other two bodies in Pland and Frostholm. As time passed, he had adapted to all of them, and adapted very well.

He also believed that even if he gained new long-term avatar forms, he would quickly adapt. Whether there was one, ten, or even more, he could

adapt.

He found that his mind was far tougher and more… strange than he had imagined. Holding several identities and several lives at the same time did not put much burden on him. The split personality and mental problems he had once worried about had never appeared.

But he still, without thinking, held back the urge to create new avatar forms and suppressed the idea of finding a corpse in Lightwind Harbor to serve as a beacon.

What Duncan worried about was not losing himself because he had too many avatar forms. He knew that the leftover feelings and memories he picked up when he occupied these bodies had only the tiniest influence on him. Those weak wills could not shake his mind in the slightest.

He worried about something else.

If he slowly turned “occupying corpses” into a habit and treated holding many fates in his hands as just a casual “way to get things done”, then someday something worse than “losing himself” might happen. After he had occupied dozens or even hundreds of living lives, would he still handle the “aftermath” of those avatar forms as carefully as he did now?

By then, there might be another Nina, but he would no longer be a responsible Uncle Duncan.

Humanity slipped away without people noticing.

So after he realized this, he decided he must treat the matter of adding new avatar forms with extra care from now on, unless the situation was truly suitable or absolutely necessary.

Of course, temporarily occupying some cultists’ bodies for investigation did not count in this caution. Those were single-use, “daily-disposable” consumables.

A thin layer of black smoke quietly rose in the mirror, and Agatha's figure appeared deep inside the smoke.

Seeing the captain looking into the mirror, Agatha quickly shrank back, pulling her image into one corner of the mirror. Then she looked at Duncan and asked: "Are you still thinking about that 'suggestion' Miss Lucretia just gave you?"

"…Maybe she still has some doubts about me," Duncan sighed softly. "There was a bit of testing in her suggestion. But that is not what I am thinking about now."

Agatha nodded and did not keep asking. She changed the topic instead: "What plans do we have next?"

"It is very simple. The Vanished will keep sailing north on this side until we pass the northern channel of Lightwind Harbor. We will see whether the dream of the Nameless One still appears when we open such a long distance, and see whether that reflected Vanished still shows up in Atlantis's dream. Vanna and the others will keep acting according to the earlier plan. Right now, the most important thing to watch is Rabby. That rabbit is hiding on the ship of the Annihilators, and those cultists will hold a gathering before nightfall today. I am very curious… what they plan to do at that gathering."

As he spoke, Duncan let out a soft breath, and there was a hint of expectation in his expression: "Next, we just wait for more news from Lucretia."

Agatha listened in silence. When the captain finished, she finally could not hold back and raised a question she had been curious about for a long time: "Then if the dream of the Nameless One really appears again without being affected, how will you go to that 'reflected Vanished' sailing in the dark

fog? Your true body is staying on the ship right now, and that ‘vine’ will only appear in Lightwind Harbor…”

Duncan smiled as he looked at Agatha in the corner of the mirror: “Do you remember? Last time, the dream of the Nameless One ended early exactly because I touched the vine from the mortal realm and entered that dark space. I took the helm of the reflected Vanished as an ‘outsider’. After I came back to the mortal realm, I told you I had an idea to solve this problem.”

Agatha frowned in confusion and said: “The idea you mentioned…”

Duncan kept smiling and turned his head to look at the view outside the window. In the mirror in front of him, he slowly lowered his head and looked at Agatha, who shared the same mirror surface with him.

The Duncan in the mirror bent down and tapped the now shrunken image of Agatha, who was only about the size of a palm: “This is my idea.”

Agatha froze for a moment. In the mirror world, she lifted her head and saw that the captain had also entered the mirror world. After staring blankly for two or three seconds, she finally let out a soft cry – and then shattered across the floor.

The Duncan inside the mirror sighed helplessly, bent down, and picked up Agatha piece by piece. As he put her back together, he muttered: “You should try to use more flexible thinking when facing life on this ship. When it comes to adaptability, you should learn more from Morris or Vanna – the former can even accept Shirley’s homework notebook now…”

…

Lucretia sat in front of the mirror, spacing out for a while. She did not know how much time had passed before she heard Rabby the rabbit’s voice

coming from the nearby scrying crystal: “Mistress, are you worried that Old Master is angry with you?”

Lucretia turned her head: “Why do you say that?”

“Because the suggestion you made at the end sounded like you were testing Old Master, testing whether he still keeps a normal person’s understanding and ‘humanity’. Old Master might care about that…”

“I did not mean to test Father. I just… did not think that much,” Lucretia said casually. Then she frowned and looked at the faint image in the scrying crystal. “But you, you even had the free time to listen in on my conversation with Father – you sound very free.”

“Rabby is easing stress, Rabby is in danger~~ Rabby must finish the task Mistress gave in the best state~~~” The sharp and annoying tone of the stuffed rabbit doll came at once from the scrying crystal. “There are only scary cultists here. They are stupid and ugly. Rabby has to talk with Mistress to keep the right state, to avoid~ eating them~~ all up~~~”

Lucretia ignored the ridiculous, eerie parts of Rabby’s chatter and said with a blank face: “Whatever. I don’t care how you plan to finish the task. If that ‘Saint’ really finds you, don’t expect me to come save you.”

“But Mistress will surely come. Rabby knows~~ you will find Rabby again in the spirit realm, then sew Rabby into a new little doll~~ can it be a little bear next time?”

“You talk too much.” Lucretia casually tapped the scrying crystal.

The rabbit finally quieted down.

…

The massive Visions 001 was slowly sinking. sunlight turned into brilliant evening glow across the waves. The light coming in through the window

seemed gentle. After a whole day of rest, the Death-Omen Bird's condition had finally improved a lot.

The time for the gathering was almost here. He could already hear footsteps now and then outside the cabin, and the sound of comrades greeting one another.

The tall, thin man with a harsh face got up from the bed and listened to the sounds outside.

He had spent almost the whole day lying on this bed to adjust his own state and the Death-Omen Bird's state. Now he had had enough of lying there.

The Annihilator named Richard let out a long breath, walked to the wardrobe in the corner, and took out the black hooded robe he needed to wear to the gathering.

He did not actually like this kind of robe. Most dark cultists were used to this outfit and believed that clothes that covered the whole body helped settle the mind and helped them draw closer to the Lord's enlightenment in meditation, but he had never thought so.

This kind of robe was not comfortable to wear, and it was not fit for moving around in the city-states at all. It had an old, stubborn feel. Wearing it made a person feel like one of those exiled prisoners from hundreds of years ago, hiding in holes in the ground and slowly rotting. Its "settling the mind" effect was even more laughable.

How could a truly devout follower need a robe to focus his mind and draw closer to the Holy Lord?

But now, Richard found that he had started to like this outfit.

It did not feel so bad to hide his whole body among his comrades.

He put the robe on and pulled the hood down as far as it would go until it covered his eyes. As a feeling of ease rose in his heart, he sighed softly, then walked to the door.

Before he opened the cabin door, a sudden breeze blew through the room. It felt as if a light body had leaped and pounced over. Richard felt a slight weight on himself, as if something had hung onto his shoulder.

A light voice spoke by his ear: “You took Rabby’s cotton… Now, let us set out.”

“All right, let us set out.”

Richard muttered softly. As his vocal cords and windpipe vibrated, he seemed to feel something in his chest itching, warm and soft…

It was only cotton.

The cotton was growing.

He smiled with relief and reached out to open the door.

Figures wearing the same black hooded robes were walking along the corridor, heading to the gathering hall deep in the ship. They spoke in low voices about the dream of the Nameless One, the Saint, allies, and news about the Ender.

Then Richard and Rabby set out.

Chapter 605: The Gathering

To go from the cabin to the gathering hall, one had to walk down a long corridor and a sloping staircase. It was a very large ship. It could not only hold many cultists but also provide space for all kinds of rituals and ceremonies. To the Annihilators who followed the Abyssal Lord, being allowed to board this ship was itself an honor.

Most cultists did not have this right. They were not allowed to board the ship, and they were not even allowed to know of the ship's existence. They could only hear secret rumors during private meetings with other comrades and hear a few words about this ship coming from other gathering sites:

There is a ship. It carries the Holy Lord's will and lets the Lord's glory patrol the seas. It is a symbol of the sect's lofty work and also the key that will open the next age full of glory…

Wrapped in his black robe, Richard walked slowly along the corridor that seemed to have no end. From time to time he met other black-robed church comrades. Sometimes someone greeted him, but he only gave the smallest response. There were also seafarers in rough cloth smocks walking in the corridor. Symbolic chains hung on their necks. They bowed respectfully and carefully to every black-robed person who passed. These seafarers were also believers of the Holy Lord, but their talent was average. They could not yet bear the power of demons, so they could only handle worldly work here and serve those "priests" who had truly gained power.

The lights in the corridor were not truly dim, but the dark colors and heavy style of the decoration still gave everything an overall gloomy look. On the

gray-white walls on both sides were iron-black candleholders carved with complex patterns. Between these decorative candleholders hung classical-style oil paintings. The paintings used large dark areas to outline landscapes unlike the mortal realm and portraits of twisted, strange faces. Dark red drapes hung down from the ceiling on both sides, covering even darker and more ominous corners.

The followers of the Abyssal Deep believed that chaotic darkness was the Holy Lord's "color" and the "base color" of this world's birth. They used this style to decorate their gathering places to try to "draw closer" to the Abyssal Deep Sea, while still in the mortal realm. They believed this could please the Holy Lord.

The dark and heavy style could not hide how rich and well made these decorations really were. Richard knew that building this ship had cost a huge amount of wealth. But there were always people to pay that cost – officials who wished to extend their lives, merchants tormented by illness, nobles tempted by power. Their offerings, when they begged the Holy Lord for mercy, had built everything on this ship.

The Four Gods Church and the various city-state authorities had built a strong set of rules for the so-called "civilized world". These rules were like an iron wall that protected those dull, mediocre ordinary people very well. But no matter how tight the iron wall was, it still had gaps. It had had them in the past thousands of years, it had them now, and it would have them in the future.

The gathering hall was here.

A heavy door stood open at the end of the corridor. Behind it was a very wide and bright hall. A tall dome, held up by thick pillars, rose overhead. Splendid chandeliers with three tiers hung down from the ceiling, and their light filled the whole space.

For practical reasons, this hall could not be kept as dark as other places. So the builders could only show their worship of the Abyssal Lord through various decorations and furnishings instead. The tentacle-like reliefs on the surfaces of the huge pillars, the dark-branch-like paintings on the far wall that stood for the Abyssal Lord, and the many strange-shaped sculptures arranged along the walls all worked together to draw a mysterious, oppressive yet solemn “worship” atmosphere.

Richard walked into the hall and stepped among his comrades. He pulled the edge of his hood down again. Then his gaze moved up to the high platform in the center of the hall.

That was where the Saint stood.

The Saint was already there.

That awe-inspiring devotee, the pure one who was closest to the “Lord” in this suffocating world, the comrade who had gone farthest on the path of the Abyssal Deep, was lifting his eye stalks from the edge of the platform and sweeping his gaze over the cultists gathered in the room.

He took up almost half of the whole platform. His huge body looked like a “crown” woven from thorns. Fearsome black bones crisscrossed and piled up like a bird’s nest on the platform. In the middle of the bones was a huge brain, almost two meters across, slowly squirming. Outside the brain, the bones formed a cage-like structure. Nerve cords stretched out from the gaps of this cage. Their ends formed eye stalks that moved slowly around the outer edge of this “bone thorn crown”, looking around. At the very top of this “crown” hung a pitch-black chain.

That pitch-black chain stretched out from the brain inside the bone cage, floated in the dust-filled air, then returned to the thorn-like bones, forming a closed ring. This form was the sign of the Saint. He had already stepped past the lower stage of a mortal making a symbiotic pact with demons. Now

his pact pointed toward himself. Little of his human nature was left. His awe-inspiring form was filled with the pure nature of Abyssal demons.

Richard looked up at the Saint once, then lowered his head in awe.

The Saint was close to stepping over the last step. Only a tiny distance remained before his chain could vanish and he could reach the highest goal of all Annihilators – gain complete purity, enter the Abyssal Deep Sea, and be with the Holy Lord.

But this great comrade still stayed here, stayed in this suffocating mortal realm. He still remembered his duty: to lead the many comrades as dull as himself to carry out that eternal work. Without a doubt, this was worthy of respect.

“Everyone has gathered.”

A deep, old voice suddenly sounded in everyone’s mind. The faint buzz of talk in the hall stopped at once. A serious air covered everything.

On the high platform, the Saint raised one eye stalk and looked toward the hall entrance. The heavy door creaked shut and locked. His voice kept sounding in each person’s mind:

“The Sun is about to set. Three hours from now, the dream of the Nameless One will open again. Before this dream opens, we must confirm the information we already know…”

Richard tensed up without thinking and, with serious focus, entered the Listening rite to the Saint’s voice.

That feeling of heat and itch came again – from his chest. It was as if something under the skin there was gently wriggling, as if fine fibers were clinging and growing between his flesh and bones, slowly spreading.

He even felt those fine fibers spreading onto his lungs and his heart, then boring on into the depths of his body.

Maybe it would not take long before he had enough cotton?

At some point, the weight on his shoulder grew lighter again. In a daze, Richard heard a little girl's voice softly laughing by his ear. But soon the Saint's voice sounded in his mind once more, making his thoughts focus again –

"…We have already carried out several explorations into the dream of the Nameless One. These included small infiltrations by comrades scattered through the city-states, and exploration missions organized by the upper priests. Comrades, you should already have heard the news. In some of these actions… we met setbacks."

As the Saint on the high platform spoke, the "thorn crown" woven of bones gave off faint cracking sounds. Some of his black bones moved. A faint glow gathered along the edges of the bone spikes and slowly flowed into the air, forming a scene that grew more and more clear.

The image formed by the gathered glow finally became clear. It showed a girl in a black dress with short black hair and a decorative bell hanging from her neck. Her body looked somewhat thin, and her face looked a bit delicate and gentle.

The girl looked about fifteen or sixteen. Maybe because she was so thin, her appearance might have been younger than her real age. But one of her arms, together with much of her shoulder and part of her torso, clearly showed a non-human state. At the end of that jagged, fearsome bone structure, a pitch-black chain stretched out. The other end of the chain led to something the Annihilators present knew all too well – a Abyssal Hound.

There was a slight stir among the cultists in the hall. Some whispered about something. Others, who already knew the details, all turned their eyes in the same direction.

Richard felt those gazes fall on him.

He tugged awkwardly at his hood. Inside, pride at having brought back important information tangled with embarrassment and unease.

Luckily, the Saint's voice ended his awkwardness in time –

"…After suffering some losses, one of our comrades finally brought back useful information. What you see here is one of our enemies.

"Do not be fooled by her appearance, believers. She is not our comrade but a being even more fallen and forbidden than a heretic cultist. She controls a powerful Abyssal Hound by unknown means. More dangerous still, her own power seems even stronger than that Abyssal Hound – her methods are cruel, and the way she acts is strange and unpredictable.

"The comrade who brought back this information is one of our outstanding members. He has rich battle experience and no small strength. Even so, he was badly hurt by the enemy's despicable ambush and almost eaten by that strange Abyssal Hound under her command… You must stay alert, because in later actions, comrades who enter the dream of the Nameless One may meet this dangerous blasphemer again.

"What you most need to guard against is this heretic's strange and vicious way of attack. Her way of attacking is…"

The Saint suddenly stopped.

It seemed that even a pure being this strong and wise would run short of words when he tried to describe that female heretic's power.

Richard pulled at his hood again. After he went back, he really should reinforce the hood a little.

Then, in his mind, he heard the Saint’s voice sound again:

“…Her way of attacking is to throw the dog.”

Chapter 606: Bewitchment

Richard believed that, at least for this one second, half the people in the assembly hall were just like he had once been. Their minds had not caught up.

And the other half had already more or less heard about this matter.

The skeletal “crown” on the high platform clicked again. The brain trapped inside the crown-like cage swelled and wriggled, and once more cast its thoughts into the mind of every cultist present:

“Yes, she really did use brute force to wield a Abyssal Hound as a weapon. The act was beyond belief, so absurd it sounded almost comical. But do not look down on her, do not be careless. That strength was far beyond what you can imagine—and she has even more uncanny traits.

“In our most recent operation, this heretic also appeared. She directly caused our ‘allies’ to suffer heavy damage. Current clues show that this heretic could resist the mental power of the Sun’s Remnant Folk. Her inner nature has very likely already shifted away from humans, or she has offered her soul to a higher supernatural being—

“She summoned a kind of emerald flame and used it to burn our allies to death. Those flames were extremely dangerous. The same fire has appeared before in Pland and Frostholm. Our current intelligence shows that this dangerous flame came from that terrifying ghost ship.

“She is a follower of that ghost ship’s captain.”

The Saint stopped. He did not directly mention the name of that ghost ship or its captain, but as soon as his words fell, a slight disturbance ran through the entire hall. The cultists of Oblivion whispered to each other. In their cautious, suppressed quick exchanges, a string of vague code names was brought up with care, and a formless tension spread through the gathering.

Richard, however, let out a breath. At least this time, most people's attention finally shifted in another direction.

After a brief pause, the Saint spoke again from the high platform: "Everyone here knows what happened in Frostholm. We suffered a major setback there. Another Saint died a martyr in the flames, and even now we cannot confirm the full picture of that failure. 'His' power almost erased everything related to the Holy Lord in the entire Frostholm sea region, including our Church brethren and the holy source in the Deep Sea.

"In Pland, the same 'erasure' also took place. The flames burned everything, including the Sun Spawn and the 'Remnant Folk'. All beings related to the incident could not escape 'His' reckoning. The entire city-state was sealed off and then purged. Information was cut off. Everyone who knew the truth vanished under the grinding misalignment of history, and then the Church of the Deep Sea false god took over everything…

"After such a thorough 'cleansing', not much information could leak out. We spent a long time investigating the truth of what happened back then, and in the end we could only confirm that it was that ship and its Master who acted… that Shadow who returned from Subspace now stands on the opposite side from us.

"And now we can be sure that 'He' has taken action once more. His followers directly caused the major losses in our recent operations.

"And He does not have only one follower."

The hall had gone completely quiet. A strange tension hung over everyone's head. The Saint moved the black bones under his body. Under his control, the light-and-shadow illusion floating in the air began to change. The girl in the black dress changed into another person—the famous "sea witch", Lucretia Abnomar.

"The heretic you saw just now has great power and a strange, vicious way of acting. But she is only one of that ghost ship captain's followers, and by no means the strongest one. Current evidence shows that the 'sea witch' has also once again begun to obey her father…"

A buzzing disturbance rose in the hall. The cultists bent close, whispering about the recent rumors spreading inside the sect. On the high platform, the Saint fell silent. He only slowly swayed those long eyestalks, letting his gaze sweep over the followers in the hall.

After who knew how long, a voice finally broke the silence. It came from near the platform, a voice that sounded a bit hoarse: "Saint, we received news not long ago that that fleet has been rebuilt. It seems…"

"It seems the news is true," the Saint's voice rang out in everyone's mind. "Most likely, more 'followers' will appear in that dream next. For now, though, only these two you have seen have clear information attached to them."

The illusion in the air shifted. The "sea witch" and the black-skirted girl took turns appearing in the projection.

"Lucretia, a witch, has mastered many kinds of sorcery and the power of the curse. She is very learned in the supernatural field. She has a powerful servant force and a ghost ship just as powerful. The Nameless One's dream can weaken her strength to some degree, and she should not be able to bring that ghost ship and her army of servants into the dream. But even if you face only her alone, you must stay on the highest alert.

“The female heretic who calls herself ‘Sarah’ very likely uses a false name. Her appearance looks very young, but that appearance may also be false. She has monstrous strength and is an abnormal contractor of demons. We can confirm that she is at least immune to the mental corruption from the Sun’s Remnant Folk. Besides the information I just mentioned, there is another extremely anomalous trait on this heretic. That is the main point I will speak of next—

“The Abyssal Hound traveling with her possesses reason and the ability to communicate.”

At once, commotion rose in the hall again. This time the voices of discussion came from all directions, even more and wider than before.

A Abyssal demon with reason?!

If these words had not come from the Saint’s mouth, the first reaction of the Annihilators on site would probably have been—where did this mad talk come from?!

Richard stood silently among his brethren. He had already expected this reaction.

If Richard had not personally experienced that unbelievable scene, he would never have believed that a Abyssal Hound could speak human words and could calmly talk with him—though that exchange had not been pleasant.

“Saint, are you telling the truth?” A cultist could not help looking toward the platform and asked, summoning his courage. “A Abyssal demon with reason?”

“It is hard to believe, but the evidence is solid.” The pile of bones on the platform slowly writhed. At some point, a faint glow had risen on the surface of the brain wrapped inside the bone cage. It seemed to be some

kind of emotional reaction. “So we must pay more attention to this special Abyssal Hound and its contractor.”

The Saint raised his eyestalks one by one. Without anyone noticing, a bright, rousing strength had entered his tone.

“That ghost ship captain’s interference is a challenge for us. I will not hide this danger from my own brethren. But our cause was destined to be full of danger from the first day. We cannot retreat and we will not choose to retreat. Our actions in the Nameless One’s dream will go on, so sooner or later we will deal with ‘His’ followers again.

“These followers are strong, but far weaker than their Master, and they are few in number. If we are well prepared, these ‘followers’ are not invincible.

“And now we can confirm that at least one ‘follower’ carries an extremely important secret. That Abyssal Hound with reason is a mystery we have never seen before on our road to seek the Truth. Perhaps the last piece of the Path of Ascension is hidden on it.

“Find that heretic who calls herself ‘Sarah’. At any cost, capture her and her demons. Comrades, the task is hard and full of danger, but believe me, it is worth your effort. The road that leads to Pure Ascension has finally shown its true form to us. These difficult trials are the proof that this road is the right one.

“Comrades, do not worry. We do not need to face that captain head-on. We only need to find his followers. That is possible… And when our cause is finally complete, when the change of eras ends, even that ghost ship captain will no longer be a threat to us. He will become a mere phantom, left behind in the final second of this Deep Sea era…”

The Saint’s voice echoed directly in the depths of every mind. On the high platform, the throne woven from black bones clicked and clacked. The

thorn-like bone spurs and shell-like structures bumped against each other like drumbeats. On the surface of the living brain, layers of hazy light curtains rippled. Along with the bewitching words, the power released from the brain stirred the spirit of everyone in the hall and slowly planted a seed of fanaticism in their hearts—

This seed took root and sprouted. It quickly pushed back the fear and tension that had risen earlier at the mention of that ghost ship and that ghost ship captain. It even turned that fear and tension into some kind of baseless drive, into firm faith and a sense of mission.

Richard lifted his head in a daze and, without thinking, let his eyes follow the Saint's eyestalks as they waved in the air. He also felt the restless heat and impulse thumping in his chest. He felt his own faith grow steadier bit by bit. The fear that had taken root in his heart after seeing those ghostly green flames earlier faded away without him noticing…

Yet at that moment, a soft voice slipped into his ear. It felt as if the voice's master were leaning on his shoulder, whispering right into his ear and drilling the sound straight into his brain: "Ah, he is talking you all into dying… Rabby really feels sorry for you…"

Richard jolted and "woke up" all at once. For an extremely brief moment, he suddenly felt a chill. He felt as if something were spreading along his chest and up his neck toward his brain. He felt that he had just heard a suspicious whisper, and that whisper came from something very dangerous…

But he only blinked, and the warning in his heart scattered like smoke.

He only looked around in some confusion, then raised his head to look at the Saint on the platform.

Why were the brethren around him so excited, so free of fear?

What the Saint had said was in fact true, and his encouragement made sense. But what about the danger in their actions? Had everyone chosen to ignore it?

Richard frowned. He kept feeling that something was wrong. This hazy feeling made him think he was falling into a strange dream. He was clearly awake, yet it always felt as if a lump of chaos and confusion blocked his thoughts, as if… his head had been stuffed with cotton.

But soon he forgot this doubt again, and the new change in the hall drew his attention away.

A sudden wave of “heat” swept across the assembly hall.

Chapter 607: Dark Allies and the Dream-Skull

A sudden wave of heat swept across the hall, as if a beam of strong sunlight had pierced the roof and was moving over the crowd. Yet as this invisible heat appeared, all the gas lamps and candelabras in the hall seemed to suffer some unknown interference and suppression. Instead, they dimmed quickly, as if sinking into shadows.

However, the Annihilators in the hall did not react much to this heat. After a slight stir, they all raised their heads to look at the dome above the hall.

Richard also raised his head. His gaze swept past the gorgeous drapes, chandeliers, and painted ceiling above the hall. They seemed to be lit by invisible sunlight. Patches of light and shadow moved slowly across the surface of the dome. Then that “sunlight” gradually gathered at the center of the dome and finally showed its source there—

It was a sphere. It looked like a blazing Sun, its surface rippling with flames and shedding dazzling light and heat. At the same time, it looked unreal and transparent, as if it were only a projection. Then this small Sun projection slowly lowered in height, all the way down to the front of the high platform in the center of the hall, to stand before the Saint.

Richard heard low voices of talk and muttering nearby. Some cultists quietly voiced their displeasure—the Outer Gods’ envoy had become more and more arrogant, even skipping the usual announcement when coming to this holy gathering place. Some cultists said that the hall should never have

been opened to the Outer Gods' envoys at all. Their mere appearance meant a stain on this holy place.

But the Saint's voice suddenly rang out in every mind and ear, cutting off the low buzzing in the hall: "Ah, our 'ally' has arrived."

As his words fell, the small Sun projection that had dropped in front of the platform slowly shed its outer shell of light and heat. That shell, like one cast from light, faded and turned transparent, and what lay within was revealed to every eye.

It was a sphere made from twisted lumps of flesh and countless coiled tentacles piled together. Between the tentacles on its surface were set innumerable eye-like structures—the Sun's Spawn.

The projection slowly stretched its tentacles in the air. One eye after another rolled and turned toward every side. Almost at the same time, another phantom-like figure appeared beneath this Sun Spawn.

It was a human, wearing a black robe with gold trim that marked the priest class among the Suntists. On the face was a Golden Sun Mask shaped after sunlight. This Sun priest's projection fell onto the high platform in the center of the hall, standing before the Saint like a spokesman.

The Sun Spawn in midair let out a deep, muffled vibration. That sound seemed mixed with layers of whispers and noise beyond human understanding. Listening to it made one dizzy.

The figure with the golden Sun mask who stood before the Saint spoke at once, relaying the meaning carried inside those muddled tremors: "I can feel that you do not welcome me."

The Saint raised his eyestalks high. "I hope you can understand. This is the Holy Lord's gathering place. For a long time, we have not allowed the

believers or envoys of the Outer Gods to step into such a holy place. But rest assured, our sincerity toward cooperation will not be affected by this."

"It does not matter. I do not care," the Sun Spawn's projection slowly stretched its body in the air and kept making those deep, vague tremors. The Sun priest who appeared with it began translating at once. "We can leave our differences in faith to the next era. dusk is drawing near. We, the races abandoned by the Deep Sea era, must first learn to live together."

"Yes, learn to coexist. When all things are remade, the world will be wide enough to hold our differences," the Saint said in a deep voice. "Is that why you came here, to stress this to me?"

"No, ally. I came to talk with you about the losses we suffered in our last operation," said the masked Sun priest. "I wanted to come to you in the daytime, but that hateful False Sun stayed high in the sky. Now that it has gone down, I have come.

"We lost many of our people, precious people, in that great forest woven by the 'Nameless One's dream'. They were burned by the flames of the Flame Usurper bearer. Even their souls did not return to the sheltering place—I must speak with you about this."

"We also feel deep sympathy and unease over the misfortune of those Sun Remnant Folk," the Saint said. His bone spurs clacked, as if showing some dissatisfaction. "But you were not the only ones whose actions suffered setbacks… No one expected 'His' power to appear there. After all, not long ago that ship was still in the far north. No one thought 'He' would intervene in this matter. His followers had already begun to move. For you to come and accuse us over this is unreasonable and rash, and rude."

"…We do not seek to lay blame on an ally." The Sun Spawn in midair stayed silent for a few seconds. The light around it seemed to draw back a little. It murmured in a muffled way, and the priest on the platform

translated at once. “But we must state our position. We are willing to cooperate with your actions in the Nameless One’s dream. Yet if you turn this ‘cooperation’ into one-sided exploitation, then our partnership will end.”

“I understand you, envoy,” the Saint said in a deep voice. “Do not worry. We will not turn a blind eye to this incident. Just now, we already decided to strike back at the followers of the Flame Usurper bearer. One of our next goals is to find the heretic who attacked the Sun Remnant Folk and our brethren, and to seize her and her demons. She is strong and insidious, but we are ready to take some risk to avenge those fallen Remnant Folk.”

“We do not care whether you truly act to avenge them, nor what methods you plan to use against those strong and strange ‘followers of the Flame Usurper’,” the priest wearing the Golden Sun Mask on the platform relayed the Sun Spawn’s words. “Do not forget our first and most basic goal. In the Nameless One’s dream there are things we each need. Work together honestly and cooperate fully. We care only about this. Nothing else matters.”

The Saint stayed silent for a moment. Then his bone spurs clicked, showing a friendly attitude. “Yes, we will each take what we need… We only want that tree.”

The Sun Spawn slowly lowered its height. The countless eyes set between its tentacles fixed their gaze quietly on the brain wrapped inside the bone cage on the platform. “We only want that Sun.”

The unreal-seeming “heat” that covered the assembly hall began to fade. The Sun Spawn floating in midair and the Sun priest standing on the platform both started to dim and dissolve. In just a few seconds, these two uninvited guests left the holy hall.

The hall stayed quiet for a while. Then the gathered Annihilators all let out their breaths. Richard also felt his pounding heart slowly calm down. Perhaps his heart had sped up without him noticing just now, because he even felt a faint ache in his chest.

He was still shaken.

Even though what had come here was only a projection, it was still a projection of the Sun Spawn—that monster split directly from the essence of the "true Sun god", like a demigod. Its very existence was a deadly source of corruption for mortals. The brethren in this hall… in the end, they still had not stepped beyond the mortal realm.

Perhaps only the "Saint" present here could stand against that so-called "Sun Spawn".

"We should never have opened this place to the envoys of the Outer Gods," someone in the crowd said, not in a very low voice. "Once their 'sunlight' shines in here, they become even more brazen."

"That 'Spawn' felt very bad to me," another voice reached Richard's ears. "We cannot understand its mind or its true intent. Every time we need a masked priest to act as a translator. No one knows how much more disturbing information is still hidden behind those translations. When its eyes look at us… it is nothing like the gaze of one thinking creature toward other thinking creatures."

"Those 'Sun Remnant Folk' give me the same feeling. I cannot sense any reason or emotion from them at all… In the end, they are monsters abandoned in the last era… long since degenerated in the dark…"

The low discussions began to spread through the hall. The feelings that had been held down started to echo with each other quickly. Yet just then, the

Saint’s voice suddenly sounded in every head, cutting off the Annihilators’ talk at once: “Silence.”

The hall fell silent at once.

“…I know what you worry about,” the Saint’s voice went on, carrying a soothing power. “But we need their strength.”

“Saint,” a nearby Annihilator closest to the platform called out, gathering his courage, “that Sun Spawn and those ‘Remnant Folk’… do you think they will really keep their promises?”

The Saint stayed silent for a few seconds.

“I have never believed those aberrations’ ‘promises’, because they were born in broken oaths from the very start. But at least before they get what they want, they have no reason to break the pact,” he said slowly. “Just as we need them, they also need us. In the time and space woven by the Nameless One’s dream, those aberrations can only ally with us.”

The questioning voices vanished.

Then the chimes that marked the hour rang at just the right moment.

Clang—clang—clang—

The mechanical clock hanging on the tall wall at the far end of the hall rang out with a long, clear tone.

“…Let us end these topics. The time is near. The Nameless One’s dream is about to link to the Mortal Realm,” the Saint’s voice quickly drew everyone’s attention. “Prepare for Dreamwalking. Those who will Dreamwalk tonight, step out and come forward. Get ready to touch the Dream-Skull.”

Richard, standing among a group of black-robed people, reacted at once. He raised his head and saw several other brethren already walking toward the

platform, including Dumont, who had come to find him during the day.

He hurried forward as well.

At the same time, several low-ranking cultists in gray robes came into the hall. They pushed a cart cast from a special, heavy alloy, its sides covered with many runes. A black cloth stained with blood lay over the cart, and something seemed to be hidden under the cloth.

“Push the Dream-Skull to the front of the platform,” the Saint ordered.

The low-ranking cultists pushed the cart to the platform in the center of the hall. Two of them took hold of the black cloth on the cart, ready to lift it.

Richard swallowed without thinking. Even though this was not his first time touching the “Dream-Skull”, he still could not help feeling a bit nervous.

That eerie thing made one feel a fear that seeped into the soul every time it was touched, and no matter how many times he went through it, that fear never seemed to become easier to bear.

His firm belief and devout faith could only help him make up his mind to touch that thing. They could not erase the impression left by the fear itself or the instinctive tension he felt now.

Then the two low-ranking cultists lifted the black cloth.

The “Dream-Skull” on the cart also entered Richard’s sight—

It was a black object that looked as if it had been carved from wood… a Goathead.

Chapter 608: Walking with the Reflection

“What did you say? They pushed out a wooden Goathead carving?!”

Duncan’s voice came from the mirror on the dressing table, and he could not hide his shock.

“Yes, a black wooden Goathead,” Lucretia said quickly. She turned her head to glance at the scrying crystal on the table beside her, trying to make out the faint image inside it. The scene came straight from the cultists’ gathering, sent by Rabby. “It looks a lot like the ‘First Mate’ on the Vanished… No, not just similar. It’s exactly the same!”

“What else? After they pushed that Goathead out, what did it do?” In the mirror in front of Lucretia, Duncan’s figure leaned forward slightly. “Is it communicating with those cultists?”

“…No.” Lucretia shook her head as she stared at the blurred image in the scrying crystal. “This Goathead seems ‘dead’… It hasn’t moved at all since they pushed it out. It really looks like just a wooden carving… The cultists are performing a ritual around it. They’re lighting candles and burning incense, and that Goathead they call ‘Dream-Skull’ still isn’t reacting.”

In the mirror, Duncan frowned deeply.

He knew that with Rabby hiding in the cultists’ stronghold, it would bring back a lot of useful information. But he had not expected that rabbit’s report to be this valuable. From the start of the cultists’ gathering until now, he and

Lucretia had watched Rabby’s constant messages, and none of them had been as shocking as this scene.

Those Annihilators… actually had a Goathead that was exactly the same as the “First Mate” on the Vanished?!

And from the look of things, that was the reason they could freely enter and leave the Nameless One’s dream?

In the mirror world dimension linked through the mirrors, Duncan stood in the dimness, deep in thought. After a long time, he finally raised his head and let his gaze sweep around him.

This was the world inside the mirror. But according to Agatha, the more accurate description was “the Vanished’s reflection on the border between the Spirit Realm and the Mortal Realm.”

Everywhere he looked, he saw the familiar Vanished. Yet the whole ship was wrapped in a strange, off?kilter air. His gaze passed through the nearby window, and he saw the deck outside shrouded in gloom. The distant sky and sea had a texture close to that of the Spirit Realm. A hazy glow shimmered along the hull. Its outline was disturbed by some unknown force, rising and rippling like a reflection in water.

Behind him was the familiar sight of the captain’s cabin: the enchanted sea chart table, the shelves, the expensive tapestry on the wall, and… Goathead, sitting silently on the edge of the enchanted sea chart table.

All of it lay under a strange darkness. Even with an oil lamp hanging on the wall beside them, even with light shining in every corner of the room, the gloom lingered, branded into the space itself. It refused to fade and constantly reminded anyone who came here that this was not the Mortal Realm.

Only one thing in the room gave off a soft, comforting glow: the Oval Scrying Mirror in front of Duncan. In it, he could see the scene inside Lucretia's room. It reflected the "warmth" of the Mortal Realm.

Duncan turned around and slowly walked to the enchanted sea chart table. He looked at the wooden Goathead lying quietly on the table. It did not react at all to his approach. It was just like… the "Dream-Skull" the cultists were using for their ritual in the hall.

He stared quietly at the dark carving for a moment. Then he reached out and patted Goathead on the head.

If this had been on the other side of the mirror, in the Mortal Realm, that move would have brought a storm of chatter. Goathead would never have let such a chance to talk slip by.

But here, in this "reflection" of the Vanished, Goathead still sat quietly, as if… it had not yet awakened.

Footsteps came from the side. Duncan turned his head and saw Agatha walk up beside him.

"Captain, there are thirty minutes until the Nameless One's dream 'comes alive'," said the lady who "lived" in the mirror world. "From my last experience, when that time comes, the Vanished's reflection will transform into the ship that sails through the dark mist, and this 'wood carving' in front of you will 'come to life' as well."

"…Yes, it will come to life, but it still won't be quite the same as the 'First Mate' I know. That one is another Goathead—and in the hands of those Annihilators, there's yet another," Duncan said slowly, his face thoughtful. "They actually used some Goathead they found from who knows where to enter the Nameless One's dream. It… makes sense, but it was beyond what I expected."

Agatha hesitated, then could not help asking: “Are there many ‘Goatheads’?”

“…I used to think there was only one,” Duncan replied, shaking his head. “It thought so too.”

“I remember you said that the ‘First Mate’ was something you brought out of Subspace. If it came from Subspace… then anything might be possible. Maybe ‘Goathead’ is even a whole race from there…”

Agatha trailed off. Clearly, even she felt that guess was a bit far?fetched.

Duncan did not answer. He just stared at the silent Goathead on the table, which looked like a real wood carving. After thinking for a long time, he murmured under his breath: “Shattered into pieces, huh…”

Agatha heard the captain’s mutter, but was completely confused: “Huh?”

Duncan did not answer her question. He just shook his head slightly: “It looks like we have one more reason to capture those Annihilators alive… This time we not only have to find a way to seize them, we also have to figure out how to take their ship.”

“As long as we know where that ship is, no ordinary vessel can escape the Vanished’s hunt,” Agatha said at once.

Duncan gave the former Gatekeeper a slightly surprised look: “You’re quite confident—you haven’t actually seen the Vanished in battle with your own eyes, have you?”

“But the scriptures of the Death Church are full of terrifying descriptions of the Vanished,” Agatha said, spreading her hands. “They say you once erased a battleship that Pope Banster—His Eminence—had just built, in a single instant… and you did it right in front of a Pilgrimage Ark, in front of an entire fleet. No matter how I think about it, there is no way those cultists built something stronger than a Pilgrimage Ark.”

Duncan’s expression froze for a moment. After two or three seconds of awkward silence, he twitched the corner of his mouth: “I’ll take that as a compliment.”

Agatha seemed to realize how awkward the topic was too. She quickly forced a clumsy change of subject: “Captain, what do you think those cultists are after?”

“Their goal? Do you mean their interest in Shirley and Dog, or their purpose in working with those ‘Suntists’?”

“Both,” Agatha said, nodding.

“Their interest in Shirley and Dog was expected. No Annihilator with a normal mind could see Dog and not be shaken. And judging from that saint’s reaction, the fact that a Abyssal demon can stay sane seems to have some special meaning to them,” Duncan said, recalling the information Rabby had sent. “That saint mentioned ‘the last piece of the puzzle on the Path of Ascension’… That line bothered me.

“As for their ‘cooperation’ with those Suntists…”

Duncan stopped there. He stayed silent for a while, thinking, before he spoke again: “The Annihilators’ goal is the ‘tree’. That is easy enough to understand. It should mean the World Tree Atlantis. And those Suntists are aiming for ‘the Sun’…”

He frowned and lifted his head, as if he were trying to pierce through layers of space and time with his gaze to look at some ‘star’ that hung high above the Nameless One’s dream, existing only in some ancient memory.

“…How are they going to obtain ‘the Sun’?”

The captain’s cabin fell silent. Agatha had no idea how to answer that question. After who knew how long, Lucretia’s voice suddenly came from a nearby mirror and broke the silence:

“Dad, Rabby says those cultists are about to start the last step of the ritual.”

Duncan immediately raised his head and looked at the mechanical clock on the opposite wall.

On its dial, where left and right had swapped like a mirror world, the hands were turning counterclockwise, slowly pointing toward nine o’clock.

The Nameless One’s dream was about to become active.

He withdrew his gaze and glanced again at the enchanted sea chart on the table beside him.

Even in this “reflection” world, the enchanted sea chart here still showed the Vanished’s normal course through the Boundless Sea. Right now, the Vanished was about a thousand nautical miles north of Lightwind Harbor, and it was still sailing north, farther and farther from the city?state.

The “test” was about to reach its conclusion. But Duncan already had a vague feeling that even if the Vanished sailed far from Lightwind Harbor, even if Goathead was taken this far away, the Nameless One’s dream would still appear. Lightwind Harbor would still be wrapped in the dream, and the Vanished’s reflection would still change just as it had before.

Because dusk was drawing near.

Because the Sun was growing gentle, and all that had once been banished would return to the Mortal Realm—just like that “Warrior” who suddenly fell into the Mortal Realm and finally turned into an unspeakable thing. The so?called Nameless One’s dream was only a realm returning to the Mortal Realm from oblivion and exile.

When dusk arrived, all these changes would happen in a way that could not be undone. The Vanished reaching Lightwind Harbor had only sped up the awakening of the Nameless One’s dream.

Just as that “saint” had declared, this so?called “Deep Sea era” was rushing toward its “last second.”

“Lucy, report Rabby’s latest observations,” Duncan said suddenly.

Lucretia’s voice came from the mirror at once: “Yes. The chosen cultists have already gathered around the ‘Dream-Skull’. They’re waiting for the final sacrificial rite…

“That saint is ordering them to bring the ‘blood food’ into the hall.

“…It’s two badly wounded elves.”

Chapter 609: ritual

Today’s blood food was brought into the hall.

Richard stood below the high platform, beside the “Dream-Skull”. He watched as gray?robed congregants pushed two elves forward. Like everyone else, his face stayed calm, but there was a faint hint of expectation in it.

The two elves, one male and one female, wore clothes that were already ragged. Under the torn fabric, their bodies were covered in marks left by many rounds of torment—not only wounds from past sacrificial rites, but also scars from all the “research” and “tests” carried out with the Dream-Skull before.

When they were first brought into the hall, their faces were numb. But when they saw the “saint” and the “Dream-Skull” below the platform, terror still spread from their eyes. They tried to struggle. However, the saint only swayed his eye stalks a little. Under his gaze, the two elves went limp, their whole bodies paralyzed and unable to resist. After that, a gray?robed congregant holding a sharp knife stepped forward.

The ritual dagger had been polished until it shone. Under the cultists’ hidden, devout, eager gazes, the blade cut into the elves’ flesh—the arms, the thighs, the back, all places that would not kill them. It was as if someone had planned to inflict the greatest pain while keeping them alive. The bloodletter cut into the sacrificial victims with skilled, silent strokes.

Yet under the saint’s gaze, the “sacrificial victims” could not even scream or struggle. The man and woman stood stiff as boards as several gray?robed people held them up beside the heavy cart. Only the sudden, twisted contortions on their faces showed the terrible pain they were suffering. Blood poured from their fresh cuts, and as if drawn by an invisible force, it floated up against gravity. Then it all flowed into a series of “blood troughs” built into the upper level of the heavy cart.

The blood flowed along the grooves toward the jet?black Goathead that looked as if it had been carved from wood.

At the moment the blood touched the “Dream-Skull”, a terrible aura and shocking power burst out of Goathead.

The Annihilators closest to it felt the surge at once. Richard felt as if countless layered shrieks and howls drilled straight into his brain. They rushed wildly through his mind as if they meant to tear his soul apart. He saw the jet?black Goathead start to tremble violently and rock from side to side, as if it were about to come to life. A powerful, malicious will, still chaotic and unclear, seemed to wake up inside it. Richard could feel its gaze sweeping across the hall.

The “Dream-Skull” had awakened.

The two elves used as sacrificial victims had already fainted. Gray?robed men acting as “deacons” dragged them aside at once. The gray?robed congregant who held the sharp knife and had carried out the bloodletting himself lifted the ritual dagger high and cried out in wild joy:

“I have been accepted! The Lord will take me in—”

The next second, a terrifying distortion fell on the bloodletter. From beneath his gray robe came the sounds of flesh tearing and bones being ground apart. His clothes bulged as the substance of his entire body was corrupted,

twisted, and crushed in an instant. Countless tentacles seemed to sprout from under his robe. His face cracked open in too many places to count, each gap sprouting a writhing tongue. Yet the sharp pain seemed to have nothing to do with him. The fanatic cheered and shouted at the top of his lungs, calling on the holy Lord's name, until his life finally faded and his warped body crashed heavily to the ground.

The bloodletter's "martyrdom" meant the ritual had fully succeeded.

"Take those two 'blood food' down," the saint on the platform ordered at once. "Keep them alive and ready for the next bloodletting.

"Gather the blood flowing out of the troughs and distribute it to the gathering sites in the other city?states. It will be used for their dreamwalking rituals.

"Those who have been chosen, step forward and touch the 'Dream-Skull'. It is time to prove yourselves."

The saint's orders were carried out at once. The two weak elves were dragged out of the hall, leaving two glaring trails of blood on the floor. Other congregants came to the eerie "Goathead" and collected the elves' blood that had touched the Dream-Skull. That blood now held the power to open a dream. It was not as strong as the Dream-Skull itself, but with the help of a ritual it could still guide a user's mind into the Nameless One's dream. It would be a key material for their fellow believers hiding in the city?states when they carried out dreamwalking rituals.

But their core explorers still had to be those "elite priests" who touched the Dream-Skull directly.

Richard took a deep breath, stepped forward, and placed his hand on the Dream-Skull's horn.

The shrieking once again pierced his mind. Terrifying pressure burst out of Goathead as dreadful power swept over him. In that instant, the Annihilator felt his mind tear free of his body. He “saw” his viewpoint rise rapidly while the world around him dimmed. He saw his flesh?and?blood body fall backward and then get caught and dragged away by the believers beside him…

In a daze, he also saw a strange stuffed rabbit doll. The stuffed rabbit doll was tiptoeing behind his body, as if it meant to hide itself in his body’s shadow to avoid the saint’s gaze…

A rabbit? Why is there a rabbit?

Richard felt a brief flash of confusion, but in the next second he forgot all about it.

The Nameless One’s dream opened its doors to him.

…

The transformation happened.

Duncan could clearly feel a change in the “atmosphere”. The scene in front of him did not seem to change much, but he knew that after the nine o’clock chime, this “reflection of the Vanished” had turned into another kind of… “thing”.

The Chronometer Clock on the opposite wall shifted back from its mirrored state. The hands that had been turning counterclockwise now resumed their normal clockwise motion. Other things in the room that had been reversed by the mirror effect also quietly returned to normal. The gloom that had filled the air thinned a little. Outside the window, the hazy deck and rail became clear again. The sea and sky that had looked like the Spirit Realm vanished, replaced by the familiar endless darkness and fog.

This was no longer a “reflection”. Now it was Goathead’s dream, sailing within Atlantis’s dream—another Vanished.

Yet for the moment, Duncan’s attention was not on the ship.

“…Those cultists actually used the ‘Dream-Skull’ by pouring elves’ blood onto that Goathead,” he said, his face twisted with mixed feelings. “And it actually worked…”

Agatha’s voice came from the mirror beside him—after the transformation, she had gone back into the mirror: “From Rabby’s description, it looks less like the ritual ‘succeeded’ and more like the Dream-Skull got provoked and then executed the person performing the ritual—and they treat that ‘execution’ as an honor.

“For now, the elves used as ‘sacrificial victims’ probably won’t be in danger of dying. The cultists will keep them alive as a steady source of blood. But before this ritual ‘matured’, many elves who served as sacrificial victims may already have died on that ship…”

Duncan did not speak for a moment. He only nodded, his face dark. A few seconds later, he glanced at the mirror not far away.

Agatha’s figure was reflected in it, but the mirror no longer showed the image of the Radiant Star in the Mortal Realm. Lucretia’s figure had vanished as well.

She, who had stayed behind in Lightwind Harbor, should have entered the “dream” by now.

“Lucy, how are things on your side?”

“It looks like the Vanished sailing away from Lightwind Harbor can’t stop the Nameless One’s dream from happening. I’m back in this forest already, and Shirley is with me,” Lucretia’s voice sounded in Duncan’s mind. “I’ve

also linked up with Rabby. It's still parasitizing that cultist and hasn't been exposed yet."

Duncan stayed quiet for two or three seconds: "…What do you think of the ritual they're carrying out?"

"A bunch of crazy idiots using crazy, stupid methods to deal with fragments of the Elder Gods. Their thinking is wrong, their methods are wrong, and the cost is huge—but somehow they still got part of what they wanted. As a scholar, I don't understand it and I don't accept it," Lucretia said. Her face was tense, and her tone carried a kind of grievance. "It's like a group of halfwits taking sticks to a broken Sorting Engine—banging and kicking it—only to somehow fix the machine. It's just…"

She struggled for a long time and finally squeezed out: "It's a disgrace to all intelligent life!"

Duncan said quietly: "But they did succeed—even if their method looks suicidal."

Lucretia's expression grew even more tangled than before.

Noticing the bitter look on the young witch's face, Duncan did not poke at her further. Instead, he changed the topic without making it obvious: "It seems there really is more than one Goathead. But not many of them have a complete, sane mind. It might even be that only my 'First Mate' does."

He paused for a moment, thinking as he went on: "And precisely because the 'Goathead' in those cultists' hands isn't fully sane, their ridiculous ritual had a chance to work. The Dream-Skull only reacts to outside stimuli by instinct. One of those instinctive responses just happens to help those Annihilators open a door into the Nameless One's dream.

"We still don't know whether they stumbled on this 'operating method' by themselves or were taught it by those rambling Enders. And even if we

figure out how the Annihilators ‘dreamwalk’, the way those ‘Suntists’ get into the Nameless One’s dream is still a mystery…”

“Do those followers of the Black Sun also have a ‘Goathead’?” Lucretia blurted out.

“Anything is possible—but my gut says it isn’t that simple,” Duncan said, frowning and shaking his head. “So far, there have only been two kinds of Sun followers who entered the Nameless One’s dream. One is that ‘spawn of the Sun’ that showed up once at the start. The other is those human?like but not human ‘Sun remnants’. Ordinary human priests and Suntists have never appeared there. And whether it’s the ‘spawn’ or the ‘remnants’, none of them are human.

“They are ‘tumors’ of the Elder Gods, with mental structures very different from humans.

“The way those things enter the Nameless One’s dream may be completely different from the Annihilators’ method.”

Chapter 610: Asleep in Twilight

Although they were both heretical cults, the Sun cult and the Cult of Annihilation had very different traits. That meant Duncan had to take their particular natures into account whenever he dealt with these cultists.

The cultists of annihilation were, in essence, humans who gained power and reshaped themselves through contracts with demons. These dark cultists clearly worshiped the Abyssal Lord, but their deity did not actually respond to that faith. So, aside from their blasphemous extraordinary power, the cultists of annihilation were still, as a whole, a mortal group. Their actions and limits still rested on their identity as humans. No matter how loudly they shouted the Lord's name, these madmen did not truly have much to do with the Elder Gods.

If you divided their cult into a kind of tower hierarchy, then from the powerless congregation at the bottom, to the priestly rank who could summon demons, and up to the so?called "saints" at the top who no longer even looked human, every level was trying to climb toward the "truth" that supposedly waited higher up. Yet the Abyssal Lord at the top of the tower had no wish to pay them any attention.

The Sun cult was different. Its structure and power passed from the top downward.

At the very top lay the dying Black Sun. This ailing Elder God, in its near? death sleep, had spawned powerful offspring called Spawn. These Spawn watched over and sheltered the humanoid monsters known as the Remnant Folk, who were actually fragments left behind by the Sun. Below them

came the countless half?mad believers of the Sun. These mortal believers had not chosen to worship the Black Sun on their own. Instead, the Black Sun's power had leaked into the Mortal Realm and warped the minds of certain humans, turning them into believers out of nothing.

So, in a sense, the entire Sun cult could be seen as an extra growth on an Elder God, a branching structure of the Black Sun's power and flesh.

When facing the Cult of Annihilation, one had to think of them as humans. When facing the Sun cult, one should first treat "it" as a chaotic Elder God. Every Spawn, every remnant, was one of that Elder God's unconscious, twitching, spasming tendrils in its sleep.

Those tendrils slipped into the Nameless One's dream. Some instinct from a higher layer drove them to steal the "Sun" that existed within the Nameless One's dream. Considering what lay above them, the way these things entered the Nameless One's dream was likely simpler and more brutal than the methods of the Annihilators—and more dangerous.

Duncan let out a soft breath and set those tangled thoughts aside for now.

"After this dream of the Nameless One ends, have Rabby confirm where that ship actually is as soon as possible," he said to Lucretia in his heart. "The sooner the better—so long as you are careful not to disturb that 'saint'."

Lucretia's voice came after a few seconds of hesitation: "Are you… worried about those elves who were used as sacrificial victims?"

"From the dreamwalking ritual, their lives should not be in danger for the moment. But those cultists may carry out other rituals, and there may be more than just those two elves on that ship," Duncan said, his tone serious. "That is one reason. The other is that I am very concerned about the 'Goathead' in their hands. Goathead's nature might really be a 'fragment of

an Elder God’. If that is true, then this fragment must not stay with a bunch of cultists. Who knows what new suicidal stunt they will try next?”

He was not sure if it was just his imagination, but as soon as he finished speaking he felt a faint… emotional shift from Lucretia’s mark. The witch seemed to be in a better mood for some reason.

“Understood. I will plan this carefully with Rabby,” Lucretia’s voice sounded again. “I will find that ship within a few days.”

“Mm.”

Duncan answered silently, then breathed out and turned his head toward the enchanted sea chart table.

The pitch?black wooden carving of Goathead was calmly staring this way. It looked completely still at the moment, but it had turned itself once just now.

It had awakened, but had not spoken.

Duncan walked over to the enchanted sea chart table and let his gaze sweep across the surface.

The lush, mysterious forest was now projected on the enchanted sea chart. It had replaced the previous ocean markings and route. The phantom of the ship that represented the Vanished was drifting slowly over the sea of trees.

On the edge of the table, Goathead’s gaze moved slowly, following Duncan’s steps.

After an unknown length of time, the usually taciturn Goathead—honestly, Duncan felt that word sounded a bit strange when used for Goathead—finally broke the silence: “You are here again, friend… You seem to have changed a little.”

“Changed?” Duncan raised his eyebrows. “What kind of change?”

“I cannot say it clearly, but the current you seems to make me feel… safer than before,” Goathead said slowly. “Before, when you appeared here, you made me confused and nervous. I could not understand your existence. But now, although I still do not know who you are, that confusion and nervousness are gone.”

Duncan quietly stared into Goathead’s eyes.

He knew that his method had worked this time.

Before nine o’clock that night, he had entered the Vanished’s reflection through the mirror, just as Agatha had done. After nine, when the transformation happened, he had become part of this “dream ship” along with the changing reflection.

In other words, he had gone from an “intruder” to one of this dream’s “own people”.

After many attempts, he had finally found the real way to enter this place. Now he could act here with his hands free. Whether he explored the ship, took the helm, or steered it into the dark fog, he would no longer wake Atlantis—or Goathead.

“Maybe it’s because we have finally grown familiar with each other,” Duncan said with a smile. Of course he could not tell a mind sleeping inside a dream that the dream existed, so he gave another explanation instead. “That is a good thing.”

“Familiar?” Goathead tilted its head a little, as if Duncan’s words made it think for a short moment. Compared to their last meeting, its hazy, half?asleep state seemed a bit lighter, though it still reacted slowly. “Ah, that does sound like a good thing… We are better friends now.”

Duncan thought for a moment and gave up the idea of going to the bridge to take the helm right away. Instead, he sat down in the high?backed chair

behind the enchanted sea chart table.

He looked at Goathead, who stared at him in silence, and then carefully asked a question: “Where is Atlantis now?”

Goathead turned its head, as if surprised by Duncan’s question. It hesitated —something it rarely did. After that almost human reaction, it slowly spoke: “Atlantis is right here. In every place.”

“Right here? In every place? Can you explain that more clearly?” Duncan frowned, then added, “I mean no harm. I just want… to talk to her. I don’t know if you can understand this, but she is in danger. There is a group of people with bad intentions who want to hurt Atlantis. I want to find her before they do.”

Duncan did not know whether that last part of his explanation had any effect, but after a short silence Goathead did speak again.

“…This place is Atlantis,” it said, staring into Duncan’s eyes. “You are already inside Atlantis. You are in her thoughts. You are in her memories. This is both the border and the heartland. But… you cannot meet her.”

From the first half of Goathead’s words, Duncan understood at once, but the last sentence still stunned him: “Why?”

“Because Atlantis has not yet remembered herself,” Goathead said. “Before she recalls everything, she is not a clear, defined existence… and right now, she does not want to wake up.”

“You mean Atlantis now exists as some kind of spiritual form, spread through this dark, dense fog, and because she cannot form a complete sense of self, she is formless at this moment?” Duncan quickly grasped its meaning and then could not help pressing, “Is there any other way for me to see her? Or at least to communicate with her?”

He remembered his past experience when he had taken the helm on this dream ship. He remembered the streaks of light in the darkness and the voices within them. He was sure those were Atlantis's thoughts. Yet those "thoughts" seemed to exist in another dimension and did not answer his calls at all.

This time, Goathead stayed silent even longer than before.

After an unknown length of time, it finally spoke—

"Let her sleep a bit longer, just a little while… It will not take long. Let her settle them down…"

…

A wild, disordered wind suddenly blew past, and drifting sand covered the view in an instant.

But before Vanna could raise her hand on instinct to block the sand, the wind and dust stopped in front of her. A voice came out of the wind: "Traveler, we meet again."

Vanna looked at once toward the source of the voice.

In the slowly calming sand, the figure of the giant came into focus.

He sat among a pile of collapsed, black boulders. Beside him lay the huge, almost exaggerated Gatekeeper's cane. The bonfire that had burned for who knew how long had already gone out. At the giant's feet there was only a heap of ash, still giving off a faint warmth and a few glowing embers.

Vanna lifted her gaze and looked around.

It was the same place where she had said goodbye to the giant before, the same sheltered spot out of the wind, the same bonfire. She had come back to this "place" with perfect accuracy, and the giant looked as if he had been waiting for her the whole time.

“I told you we would meet again soon,” the giant said with a gentle smile, wrinkles crowding his face. “See? The fire is still warm.”

“You’ve been here waiting for me all this time?” Vanna asked, a little surprised. “I thought…”

“It was only a little waiting,” the giant said calmly. “There is nothing left here but waste and desolation, and I have nothing else I need to do. Waiting gives things a bit of meaning.”

He paused, then lifted his head and looked into the distance.

“Since you are here, traveler… if you also have no goal at the moment, I want to take you somewhere.”

Chapter 611: Memories at Dawn and dusk

Vanna wondered where this giant wanted to take her.

Curious and confused, she followed in his footsteps and walked into the endless yellow desert. In the distance, the wind raised the sand into a hazy wall that blurred the line between sky and earth. At some point, the ruined city built from jagged black rocks had vanished into that wall of sand. When Vanna tried to look back, she could no longer see it at all.

The light in the sky grew brighter bit by bit, and the heat of the desert rose with it.

Vanna waved her hand and summoned her greatsword of solid ice. With the Storm Goddess’s protection she fought against the discomfort the desert brought her. At the same time she lifted her head and glanced up at the sky.

The huge crack that shone with an ominous red glow still covered the whole world. She was not sure if it was just her imagination, but the blood?like strands spreading from the edges of the crack seemed a bit wider than the first time she saw them.

She still could not see the Sun anywhere she looked, yet the entire sky kept growing brighter. It gave Vanna the feeling that the very idea of “sunlight” had been branded into some kind of cycle that ran through heaven and earth. Even though the Sun had disappeared, the light and heat it left behind still appeared in this world “on time”.

The giant’s gaze was drawn to the icy greatsword in Vanna’s hand.

He had seen the sword in her hand before, but he had never seen the process of her summoning it. He seemed to find this power very strange.

“Your sword is shaped by a power that does not belong to this world,” the giant said. “This power is very unusual. It can draw sacred miracles even in these yellow sands—I have not seen ‘ice’ for a long, long time.”

“This is an ability granted by the deity I worship,” Vanna said at once. “He is the lord of storms and the sea. Ice is the divine authority that stretches out from storms.”

“A deity who rules the sea?” the giant murmured thoughtfully. “Storms and the sea… We are very, very far from any coastline now, and what people once called the sea has already dried up. But I still remember they once built a splendid city by the sea. The city had pure white walls and many blue roofs. They named that city after a kind of gemstone, and in that city they built the first ship that could cross the great ocean…”

Vanna listened quietly as the giant told her these old, forgotten things. At the same time, she passed what she heard to the others who were acting inside the dream. The heat around her kept climbing, so she lifted her greatsword to her mouth and took a bite from it. While she chewed on the ice, she asked curiously: “And then?”

“Then that city vanished inside a bubble. When the corruption happened, many things changed in ways I could not understand,” the giant said. He lowered his head and could not help glancing at Vanna twice, at the icy sword with a bite missing. “…So that is how it is used?”

“It’s a bit hot here,” Vanna said, a little embarrassed. “I… don’t handle heat very well.”

“Not handling heat is good. Feeling discomfort in your surroundings is proof that you are alive,” the giant said. Then he stopped walking. “We are here, traveler.”

Vanna stopped as well and followed the giant’s gaze. Her expression went blank with sudden shock.

Ahead of them lay a huge… sinkhole, set into the earth like a shocking scar. Somehow, she and the giant had already reached the edge of the pit and now stood only a few steps from the wall.

After a brief daze, she took a careful step forward and looked down into the pit. The walls of the pit shone like glass. The black rock there had melted and cooled just like the ruins of the city before. The yellow sand around the edge had fallen away, exposing ground split into terrible cracks. The pit was enormous. It looked big enough to hold a city?state as large as Pland.

In the center of the pit she could faintly see something tall standing upright. It looked like a tower of incredible size, but now only a twisted, hideous shell remained. Around the “tower” she could just make out melted roads and scattered, uneven piles of stone.

“What is that?” Vanna asked in surprise, pointing toward the tower.

The giant did not answer her directly. Instead, he walked slowly to the very edge of the pit and sat down. He set the huge Gatekeeper’s cane beside him and fell into deep, quiet thought.

After an unknown length of time, he finally broke the silence.

“I have forgotten many things, but I still remember this place,” he said. “After they realized that the entire world was slowly collapsing and that human effort could not save it, they built a great archive here. The pit you see is the archive’s ruin. They tried to leave proof that they had once existed in this world, all inside a single building.

“Everything you can think of—culture, art, history, countless scrolls and crafted objects, seed vaults, and giant statues—was piled into solid, well? protected vaults. They also made huge stone slabs from the most stable materials and carved simple introductions to the world and their civilization into the stone.

“Books decay quickly. Advanced recording devices are prone to failure. Delicate storage media cannot be read directly. But words carved in stone can last for thousands of years, tens of thousands of years, maybe even longer. So those stones were placed at the very center of the archive and treated as its ‘heart’.

“They could not find any method of recording that was safer or more lasting than that.”

“Then… what happened?” Vanna could not help asking, even though she already knew the answer before she spoke.

“The stones turned into bubbles,” the giant said, lowering his head to look into Vanna’s eyes. “In a single second.”

Vanna suddenly felt as if she were choking.

“The artworks melted and flowed like water, seeping into every crack. The scrolls turned into shadows burned onto the walls. The statues sublimated into the air and turned into pale mist. Then the entire building began to sink and shatter, and the whole stretch of land sank with it,” the giant said as he lifted his hand and pointed toward the deep pit. “People gathered there—the last survivors. They wanted to mourn their civilization there and be ready to die with calm dignity. But in truth, even mourning and a calm death were luxuries.

“Right before their eyes, everything they had recorded turned into… unspeakable things.

“This is the Mortal Realm. When the world itself steps into destruction, nothing that is recorded on the ‘world’ can be preserved.”

“Then…” Vanna opened her mouth. After a long time she slowly raised her hand and asked again, “That tower…”

“When the entire building began to collapse, that place was the last safe spot,” the giant said softly. “They ran toward it, just like many, many years before, when the first great fire swept the forest settlements. Back then, they ran down from the trees and rushed toward the safe, open plains. Only this time, the ‘fire’ was going to burn more than the forest…

“In the end only one person reached that place. I do not remember what that person looked like. I do not remember if it was a man, a woman, an old person, or a child.

“That person stopped there and died standing.

“In the last minute before death, that person grew as fast as a rising mountain, as if about to touch the sky. That scene looked as if… the scale had broken, because their ‘science’ told me that a human body could never support a form that large…”

The giant raised his head and looked at the “tower” in the center of the deep pit. Even after such a long, long time, that ancient confusion still seemed to sit in his heart.

Vanna finally knew what it was.

It was the last person in this world.

Her eyes slowly widened. In her shock, she stared hard at the center of the pit.

Even across such a great distance, she could see how enormous the “tower” was. It was taller than the highest tower in Pland and even more grand than

the city?state’s great cathedral. How… could it be a person?

Yet little by little, Vanna began to see the chilling details hidden within the tower’s twisted, savage shape. She saw melted, deformed structures that rose like raised arms, and a torso that spiraled and warped. For a moment, she even felt that she saw a horrifying face set into some part of the tower.

But she knew it was an illusion. At such a distance, even if there really were such details on the tower, she could not possibly see them clearly.

Besides, it had twisted so badly that its original shape could no longer be seen at all.

Vanna could not say what she felt at that moment. She only knew that her heart had been shaken, and a flood of questions nearly drowned her thoughts. She stared for a long time at the black “tower”—the last tombstone left by the last person of that destroyed ancient civilization. Then she slowly lifted her head and stared for a long time at the sky, covered by red cracks, where no trace of the Sun could be seen.

After an unknown length of time, perhaps to push aside the heavy feeling in her chest, she suddenly asked: “the Sun… did the Sun disappear at that time too?”

“The Sun?”

Vanna raised her hand and pointed at the sky. “It was not like this before. Where is the Sun that used to shine on this world?”

“Ah, right, the Sun. I almost forgot. It is the Sun…”

The giant muttered softly. His tone carried a feeling Vanna could not understand. Then he lifted his hand and searched inside his ragged robe. After feeling around for a while, he seemed to find something hidden deep within the cloth. He took it out and held it in front of Vanna.

“The Sun is here,” he said gently.

Vanna stared at him, dumbfounded. She stared at the thing he showed her, at the object resting quietly in the giant’s palm, which was only about as big as her own fist…

A glowing sphere.

It shone with bright light and gave off a faint warmth. It seemed to float there, in a dimension parallel to the Mortal Realm.

So… small, and so calm.

“It fell down,” the giant said calmly as he looked at Vanna. “I picked it up.”

Chapter 612: the Sun That Could Not Be Taken Away

Vanna felt that her brain was not keeping up.

She was not unfamiliar with this feeling. Back in her student days, she felt this way every time she listened to Mr. Morris's lectures. But once she reached puberty and successfully let her muscles take over most of the work from her brain, she had not felt this in many years.

Now, that familiar feeling came back again.

She stared at the "glowing little ball" in the giant's hand and blinked several times. Only then did she understand, on a rational and literal level, his words and the thing in his palm. But the emotional part of her was still stunned. This was… the Sun this world once had?

"Do you want to touch it?" The giant looked at Vanna's stiff expression, smiled in a friendly way, and held the "Sun" in his hand a little closer to her. "It is not hot anymore."

Vanna felt that this line was eerily strange in a way she had never heard before, but she did not know how to respond.

After a few seconds of hesitation, she reached out almost against her own will. With a feeling she could not explain, she curiously touched the glowing little ball in the giant's hand.

It was only the size of a fist, a human fist. In the giant's hand it looked like a delicate little bead. On its surface, tiny and intricate structures seemed to

be moving. Fine streams of light surged there. Bright and dark regions alternated. From time to time hair-thin rays rose from it and then fell back to the surface.

It felt only a little warm, like water slightly hotter than body temperature.

Vanna felt a bit dazed. She thought of the Sun she was familiar with. Every day it rose from the sea horizon, bearing its brilliant double rune rings. It brought light and warmth to the whole world. It was an enormous “sacred miracle”, an ancient and magnificent “Vision”.

At the same time, she also remembered that the captain had said the Sun had another form, one even more splendid and vast. Not long ago, the captain had started trying to teach his followers some knowledge that came from Subspace. Among that knowledge were the concepts of stars and the universe.

To be honest, Vanna had not really understood the captain’s teachings. Even Mr. Morris and Miss Lucretia seemed not to fully understand them. But there was at least one thing Vanna did understand. No matter what form the Sun took, it should not be a fist-sized little ball.

That warm “little Sun” left her hand.

The giant sat on the edge of the large pit. He placed the “Sun” in his palm, rested his hand on his leg, and lowered his eyes, as if sunk in memory and thought. After a long time, he finally spoke in a low voice: “They were full of wisdom. They were good at using all sorts of methods to explain how the world worked. They were born weak, but they could rely on ‘science’ to fight things far stronger than themselves. I always thought, if they were still here, if they had developed to today, perhaps they could explain what is going on with this ‘Sun’…

“But by the time it fell, the world was already quiet. The last person had already turned into that tower. Those clever minds and all their bold ideas had vanished from this world. And I still do not understand this thing.”

Vanna stayed silent for quite a while, but she was not only silent. She was telling the captain what was happening here.

She told the captain that she might have found the “Sun” those cultists had mentioned at their gathering.

It was in the hand of this giant who called himself a deity, and it looked as if it really could be “taken away”. One hand was enough.

The giant did not seem to care about Vanna’s silence or about her mental communication with some unknown existence. Memory wrapped this lonely former god. He gazed for a long time at the little “star” in his hand, the one that had once shone on this world and on his mortal subjects. After a long while, he spoke again, almost to himself: “I have always been thinking. Thinking about what exactly destroyed this place. It did not happen in an instant, traveler. It had a long process.”

“A process?” Vanna immediately caught that word.

The giant nodded and spoke from within his memories: “At first, there were abnormal phenomena that could not be explained by any knowledge we had. The clouds would suddenly vanish and then suddenly appear again. Flashes with no clear cause formed in the air. The weather went wrong. Plants stopped growing normally.

“Then the abnormal phenomena began to spread to deeper and more unsettling fields, to what you might call the deep layers. Gravity began to shift. In many places, the flow of the Time-Stream broke and skipped.

“During this process, we saw that red light grow stronger and stronger. It was like a crack. It spread in from beyond the sky and seemed to hang fixed

above us, covering our world and twisting the starlight in the distance. Some kind of… ‘distorting’ corruption spread through the world, and no one could do anything about it.

“The Archive was founded at that time.”

The giant stopped there and looked toward the tall tower again. He seemed unused to talking with people. He would always stop halfway and sink into thought or drift off. But soon he spoke again:

“That long process had a sudden end. When the Archive was destroyed, I felt for a brief moment that some ‘thing’ touched our world. That thing spent a very long time drawing near, and its slow approach caused that long Doomsday. Its final ‘touch’ was the last arrival and the end of the destruction. Yet after so much time, I still have not figured out what that ‘thing’ was.”

“You said you felt some ‘thing’ touching this world?” Vanna could not help widening her eyes. Without noticing it, she was already using a respectful tone when she spoke to the giant. “You really did not ‘see’ what that thing was at all?”

The giant thought seriously for a moment and gave Vanna a small apologetic look. “I am sorry, traveler. I can see you care about this, but what I have said is already all that I know.”

Vanna pressed her lips together. She had to press down the regret in her heart, then let her gaze fall on the “little Sun” in the giant’s hand.

She could not let this thing truly fall into the hands of the Black Sun’s spawn and remnants.

After hesitating again and again, she finally decided to be a bit more honest.

“There are people with bad intentions. They have already set their eyes on the ‘Sun’ in your hand… I do not know if they will find this place, and I do

not know how to explain where they come from to you, but…”

She had only spoken halfway when the giant raised his hand again and set the “light ball” before her. “Do you want to take it with you?”

The giant’s tone was gentle, and he wore a smile.

Vanna froze for a moment. When she realized what he meant, she quickly waved her hands. “No, that is not what I meant. You may have misunderstood…”

“It is all right, traveler,” the giant interrupted Vanna again. He still spoke in that steady, friendly tone. “I can feel your goodwill. Also… I do not think you can necessarily take it from my hand.”

Vanna paused slightly. When she saw that the giant was not joking, she finally hesitated and reached out toward the glowing sphere. This time she was not just touching it. She was trying to pick it up.

The warm feeling came again. Vanna felt that she was holding a solid object. But just as she was about to exert force, that feeling suddenly vanished.

The sphere turned into a phantom and passed through her palm.

She stared in confusion at the Sun she could not pick up.

“I do not know when it happened, but it became part of me,” the giant’s voice came from the side. “Perhaps it was the day I picked it up. One phantom picked up another phantom, and they could never be separated again.

“Traveler, you cannot take it away, so it seems those people with bad intentions you spoke of should not be able to take it either.”

The giant stood up from the ground.

He brushed the dust from his robe and carefully tucked the “Sun” away close to his body. Then he bent to pick up that huge Gatekeeper’s cane. “We should go, traveler.”

Vanna asked without thinking: “Where are we going?”

“To walk around the world. There are still many things here. They may not look like much now, but I want to tell you what they once were and their stories.” The giant turned his head and looked at the distant sea of sand. “You can also tell me on the way where those ‘people with bad intentions’ come from. This world has been dead for many years. I have gone too long without speaking with anyone. This is the first time I have heard… news from outsiders.”

He paused and lowered his head to glance at Vanna. “I had almost forgotten what curiosity was. Thank you for reminding me.”

“Aren’t we going down there to take a look?” Vanna pointed at the tall tower in the center of the pit. “I thought…”

“There is nothing left to see there. What you see from here is all there is.” The giant shook his head and had already turned to walk into the distance. “Come. It will be dark again soon. The day and night here always change very quickly, but perhaps we can reach another ruin before dusk. Once, you could look out over the sea from there.”

Listening to the giant’s words, Vanna looked back at the “tower” once more. She said a silent farewell in her heart, then turned and caught up with the giant, who had already walked more than ten meters away.

…

Duncan sat behind the enchanted sea chart table and kept that posture for a long time. After an unknown while, he finally let out a deep breath.

Vanna had found the “Sun”. She had found it in a very… unbelievable state.

But for some reason, after hearing Vanna’s report, he felt nothing beyond the first shock and confusion. Even that surprise faded quickly, leaving only a feeling of “So that is how it is”.

Maybe it was because he had already seen with his own eyes that ten-meter-wide “Moon”. Or maybe it was because he had long ago seen a “solar prominence” that could hop along the deck. After living for so long in this strange, twisted world, his ability to accept things had been fully trained.

Then only one question was left.

Vanna could not take that “Sun” away.

That was a bit worrying.

Chapter 613: The Ship and the First Mate

At the edge of the enchanted sea chart table, the silent, pitch-black wooden carving of Goathead was quietly gazing at Duncan. Compared to the other Goathead's noisiness, this wordless stare was even more uncomfortable.

Duncan finally could not ignore that gaze anymore. He had to raise his head from his thoughts and ask: "Why are you staring at me like that?"

"I thought you would go 'take the helm' again, like last time," Goathead said slowly. "That feeling… was very strange."

Duncan raised his eyebrows and sounded a bit surprised. "You want me to take the helm again?"

"I do not know. I only felt that it was incredible." Goathead thought for a moment, and some uncertainty entered his tone. "I can sense this 'ship', and I can understand each of its parts, but I do not know how to talk to it. It feels like an old friend of mine, but I have forgotten its affairs, so it ignores me. Yet last time, when you went to the aft deck and held that wheel… I seemed to hear its voice."

"Oh? You heard its 'voice'? What kind of voice was it?"

Duncan showed a curious expression at once. Last time he had left in a hurry and had not had time to hear this Goathead talk about any of this. Now that Goathead brought it up, he at once realized he had overlooked this question. When he took the helm, the Goathead in the Mortal Realm had

awakened in shock. So what about this Goathead on the dream side? How had it reacted then?

Goathead fell silent for a moment, as if searching his memories. After nearly half a minute he slowly spoke: “Rather than a voice, it was more like some ‘things’ that appeared directly in my memory. It seemed to be calling me, reminding me not to forget the pact with the ‘captain’, reminding me not to abandon my post… I also saw some images, saw…”

He suddenly stopped, as if that half-asleep state was affecting his thoughts and keeping him from finding words to describe what he remembered. It also looked like he had fallen again into that same pause in thought and had forgotten the topic at hand.

Duncan had to remind him from the side: “What did you see? Was it an image of this ship?”

“Oh, right, it was this ship. But I do not think I was on the ship…”

“You were not on the ship?”

“I was in a very dark place. Empty… everywhere was empty and hazy. A shadow drifted over. It was this ship’s shadow, but it looked like it would soon fade away. Then a vague voice talked with me. I cannot remember what that voice said, but the master of that voice took something from me. After that, the shadow turned solid…”

Goathead spoke in a tone like sleep-talking, slow and disjointed. His words often jumped and broke without logic, like a chaotic dream that showed its bizarre, flickering scenes without any polish.

Goathead paused for another ten seconds or so before adding the last sentence: “…So I became a part of the shadow. That seems to have been a very, very long time ago, but this ship still seems to remember… Strange. Is it that it remembers, or that I remember?”

Goathead seemed to sink back into confusion. As he muttered, his voice grew lower and lower until it turned into a whisper that could not be heard at all. After a brief time of thought, Duncan's expression slowly changed. Sitting behind the chart table, his face grew serious.

Goathead's description was jumbled, with many missing and blurred details. But that did not mean it had no useful information. From those words, Duncan could fully deduce and connect many things.

What Goathead had described seemed to be the scene from a hundred years ago, when the Vanished and the real Captain Duncan Abnomar had taken him away from Subspace.

On the other side, in the Mortal Realm, Duncan had once tried in a roundabout way to ask the other Goathead about this. But that one had always given vague answers, as if it had already forgotten what had happened a century ago. Now it seemed that the information had stayed in the memory of this Goathead in the dream. Or, according to this Goathead's own words, was it the Vanished that remembered it?

Duncan gave a subtle look at the Goathead that had fallen silent again, then raised his head to glance around the captain's cabin.

This place was Goathead's dream, and in the usual sense a dream was the dreamer's "subconscious projection".

But just now, Duncan had suddenly realized something.

This ship might not be only Goathead's dream. The Vanished was alive as well.

The century-long symbiotic pact had bound Goathead and the Vanished tightly together. This bond showed not only in their physical structure but also in spirit. The latter was a living ship. Many "objects" on the ship seemed to have only the most basic life, but as a whole, as the Vanished, its

“consciousness” might be far more complex and complete than he had imagined.

Complete enough to take part in this dream in a way beyond imagining.

Duncan slowly placed his hand on the enchanted sea chart table in front of him. He gazed at it for a long time, as if he were looking through the table at the entire Vanished. He thought about the information hidden in Goathead’s description just now, his fingers unconsciously rubbing the rough tabletop.

“Are you trying to use this chance to tell me something?” he asked in his heart.

But he received no response.

Perhaps the Vanished’s “consciousness” was in a state he could not understand. It might have already responded, but no one could understand it.

Duncan thought about what Goathead had just said.

Goathead had said he once drifted in a dark, hollow place where everything around was empty and chaotic. That fit the traits of Subspace very well. He had also said the Vanished appeared before him, looking like a phantom that was about to vanish. Was that the state the Vanished had been in when it first met Goathead?

About to fade away. That meant that when the Vanished had first fallen into Subspace, its state had actually been very bad, so bad that it had already lost its body. In a sense, the ship had already been erased by Subspace at that time. Only a vague voice remained, Duncan Abnomar’s voice.

Then the master of that voice had taken something from Goathead, and only then had the Vanished’s phantom gained a body again. That “something” was the key.

Duncan’s eyes suddenly grew grave. Right after that, he remembered the first thing Goathead had said. The Vanished had reminded him not to forget the “pact” with the captain.

There was a pact, a pact between Goathead and Duncan Abnomar.

What was in that pact? When they met in Subspace a hundred years ago, what agreement had they made?

Duncan Abnomar had taken some “thing” from Goathead in order to reshape the Vanished’s body. The Vanished had taken Goathead out of Subspace and brought him into the stable Mortal Realm dimension.

Those should all have been part of the pact.

But what came after?

Duncan Abnomar had not lived until now. He had already vanished. Inside this powerful body now was a soul named Zhou Ming.

And the Goathead in the Mortal Realm plainly knew long ago that the “captain” had changed.

But it still faithfully carried out the duties of the first mate.

Was that also part of the pact?

The Goathead in the Mortal Realm had said he did not remember his experiences in Subspace. Then did he still remember this pact? Or had he also forgotten the pact, while some kind of “restriction” was still at work, forcing him to keep fulfilling the agreement?

Thoughts spun quickly in Duncan’s mind. After a moment, he suddenly stood up.

The Goathead on the table did not react at all. It did not turn its gaze to follow Duncan’s movement as it had before.

It still seemed sunk in that half-asleep, dazed state. The earlier remembering and thinking had already gone beyond some kind of “thinking threshold” for it.

Duncan did not bother with Goathead. He knew it would recover after a while. Right now, he had more important things to do.

He left the captain’s cabin and stepped onto the stairs leading to the aft deck. Following the familiar route, he reached the steering platform where the wheel was set.

With the experience from last time and with this round of preparation, Duncan did not hesitate anymore. He stepped forward quickly and gripped the heavy wheel tightly.

The next second, under the captain’s hands on the wheel, the whole ship suddenly came alive.

A familiar scene appeared again before his eyes. The huge ghost ship was waking quickly. From all over the ship came the sounds of things coming to life. The rigging tightened. The sails billowed. Ropes and winches gave off creaking noises. At almost the same moment, that vast “root tunnel”, like some passage large enough to hold a giant ship, appeared in front of the Vanished and rushed toward it like a huge whirlpool.

Countless branches, roots, and phantasmal lights drifting in the mist filled Duncan’s sight and surrounded the path ahead of the Vanished. Those warm streams of light climbed onto the deck once more and wandered aimlessly around the steering platform.

“Saslokar, is that you?”

A slightly childish voice reached Duncan’s ears. The streams of light circled around him, as if searching for something, yet also as if they were simply sleepwalking.

“…Saslokar will not be coming.”

Even though he knew the present Atlantis could not hear his voice, Duncan still answered seriously. Then he ignored the phantom lights wandering near him and put all his attention on the ship beneath his feet.

The Vanished was sailing through the darkness, moving quickly inside that huge root system tunnel. Now and then, branch-like splits appeared in the tunnel. Yet the ship seemed to know the route by itself. It did not need the captain to steer. It chose its own course.

Duncan only needed to hold the wheel.

That let him put more of his focus into sensing.

If things were really as he thought, if this ship was both Goathead’s dream and the Vanished’s dream, then somewhere on this ship there had to be parts that were not quite the same as the Vanished that now existed in the Mortal Realm.

Those would be the subconscious reshaping the dream, the replay of memories.

They were things the Vanished was trying to show him.

Chapter 614: Beneath the Fault

Duncan felt his thoughts spreading through the ship. His senses fanned out like a spiderweb, and every part of the vessel seemed to become part of his own body. It went more smoothly than last time, clearer than last time. This ghost ship sailing along the edge of the dream was laying all its secrets bare to him.

His mind began to sink down layer by layer. It went from the tall aft deck, to the cabins below, to the intermediate decks that stored powder and shot, then to the locker that held the anchor chains and the water tanks. It slid along every wall and every pillar, every rope and every consecrated lantern.

The whole ship slowly turned into a fine, detailed “projection” and floated in his mind.

Duncan compared the structure in his mind with his memories, hoping to find something that did not fit. Maybe it would be a beam that was not in the design. Maybe it would be a cabin that had never appeared in the Mortal Realm. Maybe it would be a hidden compartment no one had ever found. That would be where the Vanished and Goathead were misaligned in their fused consciousness.

At first this was only a sudden thought. Duncan had only realized that this ship was not Goathead’s own dream, and that the Vanished’s own “memories” might also be at work in it. So he wanted to look for proof that the latter existed. But as his perception kept spreading across the ship, that “let’s try it” thought grew firm. It was as if an invisible voice was giving him mental guidance and telling him—

There really was something hidden deep inside this ship. The Vanished really wanted to tell him some secrets. In some place that could not be seen from the Mortal Realm, the Vanished still “remembered” things that had once happened in Subspace.

And that hidden memory pointed to one of the core secrets in this tangled dream—

the origin of Goathead, and the link between this dream ship and Atlantis.

Was it his own intuition? Or was the Vanished really whispering to him without stop?

A vague idea rose in Duncan’s heart, but he did not get stuck on the question. He focused on his work and searched for any clues that might exist.

It was not easy. Even with the ship he knew best, Duncan did not dare claim he could clearly remember where every single item lay on the Vanished. He could only hope his “intuition” would work in this process and help him find some place that felt wrong.

But he had not expected that he would not need any help from intuition at all. The wrongness was even more obvious and jarring than he had imagined.

Under the third deck, he sensed a large… “perception fault”.

Duncan frowned at once. He gripped the wheel in his hands and looked down toward the place he “saw” in his perception. It was right below him.

The bottom of the ship?

Something suddenly came to Duncan’s mind. He hesitated, then let go of the wheel.

His link with the “helm” broke.

But the perceptions the whole ship sent to him did not stop. He could still feel that this ship was linked to him. The ship still sailed fast through endless darkness and mist, and in the dark space beyond the rails, those vast structures like plant roots and branches still existed and kept flashing past on all sides.

The “flowing light” of Atlantis was there as well, still circling nonstop around the bridge.

Looking at this scene, Duncan had a faint realization. It seemed that once the link was formed, it would not break until this dream ended.

Because he had entered by Dreamwalking through his reflection, he was now also a part of this dream. The actions he took here would no longer be treated as “outside invasions”, and the dream’s own power to repair itself would not easily drive him out or erase him.

After he confirmed this, Duncan let out a breath of relief and quickly left the bridge. But before he went deeper into the ship, he turned back on the aft deck and returned to the captain’s cabin.

Near the door of the captain’s cabin, he saw the old-fashioned consecrated lantern hanging quietly on the wall.

To go down into the lower structure of the Vanished, he needed to carry a consecrated lantern. Even though he did not know if this rule still had to be followed on this “dream ship”, he still chose to act with care.

Agatha’s figure appeared in a nearby mirror. She looked at Duncan with some curiosity and said: “Captain, what are you going to do?”

“I am going to the bilge,” Duncan said quickly. He glanced back toward the chart table. Goathead still crouched there in silence and showed no reaction. “There is something at the bottom of the ship.”

Agatha froze for a moment when she heard this. Her expression turned serious at once.

“We will talk as we walk,” Duncan added at once. “Do not discuss it here.”

As he spoke, he had already taken the old brass consecrated lantern, opened the door, and stepped out of the room.

He strode across the empty deck, which was filled with thin mist. The Fire Seed had already lit the consecrated lantern, and the flame in it gave off a ghostly green light. The drifting fog around him drew back a little in the lamplight, then closed in again behind him. In the light and shadow cast by the lantern, an extra shadow moved quickly at his side, almost overlapping his own.

Agatha’s voice came from that shadow: “The bilge you are talking about… is it the area you usually do not let me go near?”

“Yes,” Duncan nodded. He opened the door that led to the lower deck and went down the stairs quickly with the consecrated lantern in hand. “In the Mortal Realm, the bilge of the Vanished connects to Subspace. Down there is a broken region. Beyond every crack is a scene mirrored from Subspace. If I am not with them, it is dangerous for anyone to go near.”

“…It already sounds dangerous from how you describe it,” Agatha’s shadow seemed to shiver. He could not see her expression, but the shadow clearly grew a bit lighter, as if she was a little nervous. “From how you are acting, it seems that on this ‘dream ship’, the state of the bilge has changed?”

“A structure I have never seen before has appeared there,” Duncan said quickly. He went down the stairs beneath the deck and passed through the empty, dim storage rooms, going deeper layer by layer. “It is not far ahead. The broken region is at the bottom of the last set of stairs…”

After they moved as fast as they could through those dimly lit corridors and stairways, where the atmosphere was eerie and even the light and shadow sometimes showed Inversion, Duncan and Agatha's shadow suddenly stopped.

They had reached the end of the last stairway. The door that led to the shattered region in the bilge stood quietly before Duncan's eyes.

Agatha's shadow "crawled" along the steps to Duncan's side, then slowly rose up the wall. Judging from the outline, she seemed to be watching the door ahead with both care and tension.

"I cannot feel anything on the other side of the door," she said in a low voice. "Even at this distance, I cannot feel it… it is as if the other side of the door is pure 'emptiness'."

Duncan glanced at Agatha, then lowered his eyes to the consecrated lantern in his hand.

The glow from the consecrated lantern lit the area around them in a soft way, but when it fell on the door ahead, it seemed to be absorbed by something. Only about half the brightness remained.

He drew a slow breath, stepped forward, and pushed the door open.

In the Mortal Realm, the space behind this door was the shattered bottommost cabin of the Vanished. It was the structure that floated in Subspace.

But here, what rushed into Duncan's eyes at first was a boundless darkness.

He almost thought he was about to lose his footing and fall into that darkness.

Duncan felt his nerves tighten without thinking. The vast darkness was too strong a contrast with the scenes in the cabins before, and it caught him off

guard. But soon, he saw that there were other things inside the darkness.

His eyes slowly adapted, and he saw the huge things that loomed in the dark:

First there was an enormous continuous structure, wide like a road floating in the void. Its two ends rose up slightly. Then he saw clearly many “branches” joined to both sides of that continuous structure. They lined up neatly in the dark and stretched all the way to the edge of his sight, like… ribs.

Duncan stood in the middle of this vast continuous structure. He saw that apart from the “main trunk” under his feet and the smaller branches around it that looked like ribs, there was no sign of any hull wall here at all, not even shattered pieces. Between those “ribs” there was only dark emptiness. Wisps of fog rolled in the darkness and wound through this wide space.

Duncan knew what it was.

At the same time, Agatha’s shadow also “crawled” out through the door and fell beside Duncan’s shadow. She stared in shock at the unbelievable scene in front of them and only reacted after a moment: “Wait, this thing is…”

“The keel of the Vanished,” Duncan said in a low voice, nodding slightly.

“The keel… right, the Vanished is a sailing warship built a century ago. Of course it has a keel…” Agatha spoke in a hesitant way, and her tone sounded a bit strange. “But it looks…”

Duncan did not answer Agatha. Almost all his attention had been drawn to that amazing structure that curved and stretched away in the dark.

This was the first time he had seen the keel of the Vanished. According to this world’s shipbuilding rules, a finished sailing warship would never expose its keel in any visible part of the interior. The “bottom compartment” of the Vanished where the keel could once be seen had

already shattered and floated in Subspace, and the keel's structure could no longer be told apart there.

He had never thought about what the keel of this ship would look like.

Now he knew.

He stepped onto that "road" floating in the dark, walked along it, and stopped in front of the first "segment".

The light from the consecrated lantern lit the huge bulging joint in front of him. Farther away lay the next "segment", and more segments after that.

This kind of segmented "jointed structure" clearly did not meet the building rules for a sailing ship's keel. For an ordinary Old Era sailing ship, the keel had to be a single, whole piece of wood. Only then could it endure the waves on the sea.

But Duncan believed that this keel at the bottom of the Vanished, with its many "jointed segments", was surely stronger than any other keel in the world.

Because it was the spine of an Elder God.

Chapter 615: Shattered Secrets

Looking at the keel that stretched forward into the dark, Duncan felt he could already be sure of its origin, and of the “deal” that had taken place deep in Subspace a century ago.

But he kept feeling that he had missed something. He felt this was not what the Vanished wanted to tell him—at least, not all of it.

He lifted the consecrated lantern higher. The flame lit by the spirit flame grew a little brighter. Its gentle glow lit the area around them and made the details on the keel’s surface stand out more clearly. The firelight also shone on the empty regions beyond the keel and spread through the dark mist.

Shapes seemed to flicker in the mist, as if many things were hiding there.

Agatha’s shadow followed. She rose up in the mist and stood dimly at his side. “This… spine, could it come from the great demon god Saslokar of elven legend?”

“The chance is very high,” Duncan nodded slightly. “And I fear only a being on the level of a deity could have a spine like this.”

“Goathead…” Agatha hesitated. Her thoughts seemed tangled, and it took her a long time to find the right words. “I mean all the Goatheads. The one on the Vanished, the one in this dreamscape, the ones in the hands of those cultists, and the ‘Goatheads’ that may still be unknown. What do you think their relationship is with Saslokar?”

She paused, then went on: “That muddled Goathead said that Saslokar died a long time ago, and that it was not Saslokar. But now it seems that ‘they’ all have a close link with the ‘primordial dream’ of the elves. Now we have even found this ‘keel’ at the bottom of the Vanished… You no longer remember how you got this keel in Subspace back then, do you?”

Of course, Agatha did not know that the Duncan now was not the Vanished’s original “captain”. She naturally believed that the one who had made an agreement and signed a contract with Goathead in Subspace a hundred years ago was Duncan. He often said that he had lost many memories while he was regaining his humanity. So she took it for granted that this keel was also one of the memories Duncan had lost.

Duncan did not answer her directly. He only nodded lightly, then thought for a few seconds before speaking in a thoughtful tone: “Perhaps all the Goatheads are parts of Saslokar.”

Agatha was stunned for a moment, but soon understood. “So Miss Lucretia was right to call those ‘Goatheads’ in the hands of the Annihilators ‘Elder God fragments’… And these Elder God fragments are all in different states and cannot understand themselves. Some still remember things related to Saslokar or Atlantis, and some seem to have completely lost thought and reason…”

Duncan stayed silent and just stared at the massive spine before him, lost in thought. After a long time he suddenly spoke. “Let us be bolder with our guess. ‘Goathead’ may be only one form that an Elder God fragment can take. The spine in front of us is clearly another form of ‘Elder God fragment’. And there may well be other forms of Elder God fragments: a tree, a person, a stone, a corpse… all of them could be parts left behind by Saslokar.

“After all, in the old myths of the elves, Saslokar had countless forms. That can also explain why Goathead, which seems to be an Elder God fragment, is small enough to sit on a chart table, while this spine, which is also a ‘fragment’, can support the entire Vanished.”

Duncan spoke of the possibility he had thought of in a calm voice. But the picture it painted was chilling. Even Agatha, who had once been a Gatekeeper, felt a cold shiver when she tried to imagine the state of that great demon god.

She could not help but speak. “What kind of power… could turn a ‘deity’ into this? Into this… torn-apart state?”

She had only spoken without thinking and did not expect any answer from the captain.

Yet after a brief silence, Duncan did speak. He spoke slowly, as if talking to himself—

“…But the second Blueprint also failed. And so, in the second Long Night of the Genesis Protocol, the King of Dreams was torn apart. Part of Him drifted along the border of the Mortal Realm…”

Agatha froze at once. Her shadow quivered a little in the light, and its edges looked a bit blurred. Soon she remembered where those lines came from. “That is written in the Blasphemous Tome…”

Duncan nodded slightly. “Yes. It is the ‘creation myth’ of the Annihilators, the story from before the age of the Deep Sea began. The King of Dreams used His divine authority to create the world, yet in the Long Night He was torn into pieces.”

“Saslokar is one of the lost Elder Kings!” Agatha understood. “This ‘great demon god’ from the ancient legends of the elves is the ‘King of Dreams’ who tried to remake the world in the second Long Night?!”

“I actually had this thought long ago, since Their Divine Authorities are so close,” Duncan said. “But for a long time, the ancient legends of the elves lacked any proof. Saslokar, as a faith element unique to the elven race, has many legends and sacred miracles that go against the records and facts from the other city-states on the Boundless Sea.

“There is also another important point. The elves have the most complete myth system and history of all the races. Yet in their own records, there is never any mention of ‘the King of Dreams trying to reshape the world in the second Long Night’. There is no description of this great demon god being torn apart at the end of the Long Night, not even in doubtful unofficial stories.

“These contradictions kept me from daring to treat the ‘great demon god Saslokar’ in elven legend and the ‘King of Dreams’ from the second Long Night as the same deity. Not until now… when I have seen with my own eyes the fragments left behind by this torn-apart Elder God.”

Perhaps because she was lost in shock and thought, Agatha stayed silent for a long time. Duncan walked forward slowly. Holding the consecrated lantern, he carefully stepped onto one of the joints of the “Elder God’s spine”, then bent down and touched its rough, weathered bone with his hand. It felt as if it had been battered by countless ages, yet it was still tough and reliable.

This spine had brought the Vanished, which had sunk deep into Subspace and was almost completely swallowed and erased by it, back into the Mortal Realm. It had given the ship a new body and carried it for a full century.

His movement suddenly stopped.

A question he had never thought of before, one that had been overlooked for a long time, pushed into his mind and would not be held back. Now that

he had seen this “keel” made from an Elder God’s spine and understood in a clearer and more direct way what shocking structure lay at the bottom of a giant ship, Duncan finally thought of this question—

What had the original Vanished used as its keel?!

He straightened up in a rush and looked around at the vast dark space.

The frame of the hull bottom, held up by the keel and ribs, was half lost in endless mist. In the distance he could faintly see broken hull planks and the support structures of the upper levels.

This structure built on an Elder God’s spine was huge and complex. It inspired awe.

But this was not the original Vanished. Not all of it.

The first Vanished had long since been swallowed by Subspace. When Goathead saw it, the ship was already nothing but a faint phantom and the obsession of Duncan Abnomar himself.

The “Vanished” that Duncan knew now was the result of that phantom being made solid again. Its original keel had been replaced with the spine of an Elder God, and only then could it perform the “sacred miracle” of sailing back from Subspace.

Then what about this ship’s original keel?

Duncan was not an expert in shipbuilding. But after living in this world for so long, he had learned many basic facts about ships. He knew how sailing warships had been built a hundred years ago. He knew that only a single piece of wood that had been carefully picked and was extremely tough could bear the burden of the “keel”. The strength and size of that timber set the limit on the maximum size of every sailing warship.

Yet the Vanished was far beyond that size—not just a bit bigger, but twice as big.

The Vanished was the largest sailing ship this world had ever seen. No larger sailing ship had appeared after it. From the structure here in the bilge, the keel part of the Vanished had not used any riveting or splicing techniques either.

Duncan slowly frowned.

The keel was the most basic part of a ship. The way it was built directly decided the rest of the ship's structure. So this "Elder God's spine" before him should only have replaced the Vanished's original keel, and not changed its basic structure on a large scale. That meant the Vanished should have used a single, whole keel, just like the other sailing warships of that time.

But there could not be trees that big in any city-state.

Even if there were, the strength of the wood itself had a limit. At the scale of the Vanished, it would far exceed what a traditional wooden keel could carry.

Unless from the very start this ship's keel had not been ordinary wood, but some kind of… far more unbelievable material.

Over the past century, the Vanished had been one of the greatest taboos on the Boundless Sea. Many things related to it had become topics people did not dare mention. Although the ship had been built in the city-state of Pland, almost no one would talk in public about how it had been built back then.

But now Duncan could imagine that more than a hundred years ago, when work had just begun on this astonishing exploration ship, it must have been a major event.

Fog flowed slowly on all sides. The pale green light from the consecrated lantern soaked softly into the mist, as if outlining many vague shapes.

Duncan looked at the mist coiling around them and not fading. His brows slowly relaxed.

“So this is what you wanted to tell me…”

Chapter 616

Nina and Morris walked along the forest path. Daylight streamed through the thick canopy overhead, casting mottled beams across the woods. At some point a thin layer of mist had risen among the trees, and the sunlight diffused through it, making everything look even more dreamy and hazy.

The elf maiden who called herself “Celine” walked a short distance ahead. From time to time she stopped and glanced back at them, always looking endlessly patient.

“The forest is getting foggy,” Nina looked up at the distant, layered shadows of the trees and said quietly in her heart: “It’s the first time I’ve seen fog here… Uncle Duncan, how are things on your side?”

She slowed her steps, her face taking on the focused look she had whenever she tilted her head for the Listening Rite. Morris, walking beside her, also slowed down and listened carefully to the voice that came from deep within his thoughts.

A moment later, the old scholar’s voice sounded in the mental link: “You mean… the construction records for the Vanished? The old data from the Pland shipyard?”

Then the old man listened for a while longer. He nodded with a serious expression and replied in his heart: “I understand… Those records must still exist, but we definitely can’t get them by normal means. I’ll talk it over with Vanna later and see if we can look for some old friends in the city? state, or maybe approach the Church.”

The voice from the depths of their minds slowly faded.

Nina blinked and looked curiously at her teacher walking beside her: “Why did Uncle Duncan suddenly want the old construction records for the Vanished?”

“I don’t know. Maybe the Captain found something deep inside that ‘Vanished in the dream’,” Morris said casually. “But since he didn’t tell us the details, we’d better not ask on our own.”

Clearly, after serving on the Vanished for so long, the old gentleman had become very skilled at following the safety rules around the Captain.

He paused, then frowned slightly as he watched the white mist coiling through the dense forest, growing thicker with every passing moment.

“The fog is getting thicker…” he said, his expression turning grave. “I don’t know much about forests, but I can’t shake the feeling that something is wrong with this fog.”

Nina thought for a moment, already eager to try: “Should I use sunlight to disperse it?”

Morris glanced reflexively at Celine walking ahead, then quickly waved his hand to stop the young lady’s enthusiasm: “Don’t be reckless. Your sunlight seems to be a very strong stimulus to this dream.”

“Oh…”

And while they were delayed like this, Celine, who walked in front, stopped.

It was as if she could always sense with perfect accuracy the distance between herself and Morris and Nina. Whenever that distance grew too wide, she stopped at once, sometimes even asking about it or urging them on, just like now.

“Did something happen?” The elf maiden looked back in confusion at the two of them muttering in the rear. “We don’t have much time to waste. We have to get back to the Wall of Silence before we run into any corruption phenomena.”

“There’s a lot of fog all around us,” Nina hurried a few quick steps to catch up to Celine and took the chance to ask directly: “Does it get this foggy here often?”

“Fog?” Celine froze for a moment, then lifted her head to look around. A look of sudden understanding crossed her face, and she smiled faintly at Nina. “We’re very close to our destination already… We are almost inside the Wall of Silence.”

“You mean this mist is caused by the Wall of Silence?” Morris’s voice came from the side at once. “Or rather, that this ‘fog’ is itself a part of the Wall of Silence?”

“It’s magnificent, isn’t it?” Celine did not answer the scholar’s question directly. Instead, with a strange, excited joy, she looked around at the dense forest that the mist was slowly swallowing, as if she were the one seeing the Wall of Silence for the very first time. “From here, you can’t even see its full shape, but Atlantis can. From very high up, from the sky, Atlantis’s branches can look down on this wall…

“It closed before her eyes, shutting the whole kingdom away from the corruption outside… We aren’t there yet, there’s still a little distance. Deep in the fog there is another barrier, forged of light. That is the true body of the Wall of Silence, and it’s already very close, just a blink away…”

Celine spoke in high spirits. This “mind entity”, who had seemed especially calm and even a little stiff all along the way, suddenly gained a burst of lively human warmth in just a few seconds. She turned, hurried down the path into the thick fog, and waved to Nina and Morris as she went:

“Come on, keep up with me, we’re about to return to a safe place!”

It was the first time Nina had seen her act like this. She froze for a second before she came back to herself, only to see Celine’s figure already close to vanishing in the shifting depths of the thick fog. She hurried to chase with Morris, quickening her pace, yet for some reason she faintly felt…

That she would not catch up.

Before this, Celine had always waited for her and her teacher whenever they fell behind. The “Celine” that Shirley and Miss Lucretia met had shown the same “behavior pattern”. But this time, Nina felt that Celine would not stop and wait anymore. Celine’s steps held no hesitation at all. She almost rushed into the shadowy trees within the fog, like a traveler returning home after a long absence, like a drop of water going back to the sea.

The elf finally vanished into the boundless fog and never looked back.

Nina and Morris were left staring at each other in the mist?wreathed forest.

After a short while, Morris looked thoughtfully toward the direction where Celine had disappeared. “Her mental signature vanished right at the end of this path, within a few seconds after her figure left our sight.”

Nina thought for a moment, then asked uneasily: “So are we already lost… ? There is fog and trees everywhere, and everything looks the same.”

“We never knew the way in the first place,” Morris said, taking it rather well. “You don’t need to worry about being ‘lost’ in a dream, because in theory, whenever you move around inside a dream, you are lost by definition.”

Nina listened to her teacher’s lecture in a daze and felt it made a lot of sense. “That’s true.”

Then she asked another question: “So what do we do next? Do you need me to ‘fly’ up there and take a look around? I can hold back a bit.”

“Unless we have no other choice, try not to provoke this dream,” Morris said, waving his hand. Then, in the thick fog, he roughly confirmed the direction where Celine’s mental presence had vanished. He raised his hand and pointed toward the end of the narrow path ahead. “We’ll go this way, along the last route Celine showed us.”

“Alright!”

So the two of them, one old and one young, began trudging through the mist and forest that seemed to have no end.

They had only a general direction.

But Nina still remembered what Celine had said before leaving: they were only one step away from the Wall of Silence. In some distant past, the Sanctuary World that Atlantis built for the elves lay just beyond this thick fog.

It was only a blink away.

At some point, the daylight that fell through the gaps in the canopy had grown dim. The mottled beams turned into vague, suspicious shadows in the thick mist. The ground of the forest was rough. The narrow tracks stamped out by beasts on their way to water hardly counted as “roads”, and even those tracks did not appear everywhere. In many places, the fallen branches and leaves made the ground softer and harder to walk than those uneven paths.

And she did not know if it was just her imagination, but Nina felt the ground became harder to walk the farther they went. The plants grew denser and more tangled. Vines and bushes crossed and spread out as if they meant to block the way on purpose. A chill spread through the mist, as if what lay

ahead was not a “final refuge” at all, but the greatest shadow in this vast dream.

She suddenly stopped.

In the dense fog, she seemed to see something flash past.

Nina almost unleashed a six?thousand?degree?Celsius slap.

But she managed to hold back that overly radiant burst of sunlight at the last second.

“Just now it felt like something ran past in the fog,” Nina said to Morris, a little nervous. “It gave me a scare!”

Morris glanced at Nina and saw two golden flames flickering deep in the young lady’s eyes. The air around her was slowly settling after a brief, warped distortion.

The old gentleman suddenly looked a little tense as well. He was not afraid that something dangerous might actually appear in the fog. He was afraid Nina would light up the forest with one slap.

After all, this child tended to explode the moment she was startled.

“Did you see clearly what it was?”

“No.” Nina shook her head. “I just felt like it was a very tall ‘person’ who ran past in a flash. But it might not have been a person. The outline felt strange… like it was distorted.”

“…We can’t tell what that was for now,” Morris said with a frown. “But I didn’t sense any mental activity just now, so it is very likely only an illusion born from the fog… We still don’t know how this so?called ‘Wall of Silence’ works, so anything we see inside it is possible.”

He paused, then could not help adding: “The key is that you stay calm, and keep control over your urge to lash out.”

Nina nodded nervously. She kept watching the mist around them and walked a few more steps forward.

Just then, a gust of chaotic wind seemed to blow through the forest.

She felt the fog in front of her suddenly thin out. Right after that, a vague curtain of light, like a warped mirror, appeared at the far edge of the dispersing mist.

That faint glow trembled in the mist, its surface reflecting a twisted view of the forest. Something seemed to lie behind the curtain of light, but it was hazy and impossible to see clearly.

Nina went blank for a moment, then realized they had arrived.

That was the “barrier forged of light” Celine had mentioned at the end of the Wall of Silence.

In the next second, Nina and Morris hurried up to the curtain of light.

A rampart forged from light stood at the border of the fog, grand and imposing, like the very end of this world of forest and trees. It stretched upward into an endless sky and outward to either side into endless distance. Ripples of light slowly flowed across its surface, as if it sealed off the worlds on both sides of the glow and quietly guarded the boundless secrets beyond.

“It’s… so beautiful.” Nina lifted her head in a daze and praised it without thinking.

Morris stepped forward. He had Nina step back a little, then carefully stretched out his hand and touched the layer of light that seemed to have no thickness at all.

And then the Wall of Silence collapsed without a sound.

That light?forged wall, which seemed to link heaven and earth and stretch without end in majestic, solemn glory, shattered like a soap bubble.

Chapter 617

Nina had never imagined this scene would happen. She had pictured changes after Mr. Morris touched the curtain of light, something rushing out of it, or the world around them turning upside down. She had even imagined a loud crack as Uncle Duncan and the entire Vanished fell from the sky. But she had never imagined it would be like this.

That curtain of light, which was likely the Wall of Silence, simply burst like a soap bubble, silent and weightless.

The grand wall of light that formed the barrier cracked into fragments in an instant. The structure that had once seemed to hold up heaven and earth scattered into motes of light in the blink of an eye.

At the moment the barrier shattered and vanished, the whole forest seemed to fall into a brief stillness. A second later, the mist that filled the woods began to flow again. Nina finally came back to her senses and ran over to her teacher in a few quick steps.

“Mr. Morris!” she cried. “Are you alright? How did that thing suddenly…”

“I don’t know…” Morris was clearly dazed as well. The old scholar, who usually seemed steady, reliable, and cultured, actually looked a bit at a loss. The corner of his mouth twitched, and for no reason he recalled the seven rules of archaeology that Teacher Rune had taught him years ago when he was studying at the Truth Academy:

“First, don’t touch things at random; second, handle the surroundings with care; third, don’t touch things at random; fourth, don’t jump to conclusions;

fifth, don’t touch things at random; sixth, respect the traces of civilization; seventh, for heaven’s sake, don’t touch things at random…”

The old man lowered his head and looked blankly at his own hand. After so many years, he finally felt that familiar thought again: this absolutely must not reach his teacher’s ears.

But soon those jumbled thoughts were cut off by Nina’s sudden gasp beside him.

“Ah…” Nina could not hold back a small cry. At the edge where the shattered curtain of light had been, in the mist that continued to pour out of the forest, she stared wide?eyed into the distance, at the place that had once been hidden under the Wall of Silence.

Morris instinctively lifted his head and followed Nina’s gaze.

There, the daylight was dim and the sky was murky. Chaotic mist shrouded everything. It was the end of the forest, where wide chains of mountains and hills stretched on. In that endless fog, something vast slowly began to take shape.

At first, Morris thought it was a mountain, a jagged, twisted mountain of strange shape.

Then he realized it was a tree. A giant tree almost torn to pieces, its remains coiled and twisted as they covered the land, leaving its original form nearly impossible to imagine.

The crown that had once been enough to cover an entire plain had collapsed. The trunk had broken and fallen apart. All lush green had long faded from it, as if burned away by fierce fire. Only twisted branches like savage bones remained, jutting strangely toward the sky.

There, the huge branches rose like towers and the broken roots loomed like cities. The dreadful remains formed a wasteland like Doomsday itself. Ash

the color of bone and fine dust filled every crack in the ground, spreading a pale, savage field around the giant tree. Morris and Nina stood at the edge of this dead kingdom, as if they stood on the border of the world's Doomsday, gazing at an ancient Day of Ruin.

A light wind blew from above that land of ash, lifting a fine pale dust. It mixed with the thin mist drifting out of the forest and coiled around Morris and Nina.

In the chaotic wind, Nina seemed to hear someone whispering beside her, and the voice sounded a little familiar:

"…Because she knew from the very beginning that the Wall of Silence could not save anyone. She was only a little sapling. When that day came, the only thing she could give them was a beautiful bubble…"

Nina's eyes opened a little wider, and she turned at once toward the direction of the voice.

But there was no one there, only a small tree.

A thin little tree stood there, rooted quietly in dust and ash. Its trunk and branches grew upward in crooked lines, while the outermost twigs drooped and swayed left and right in the breeze. It looked… just like the tree Shirley had mentioned, the one Celine finally turned into.

Every tree in the Nameless One's dream was taller and stronger than this one.

Nina slowly walked over to the little tree. She hesitated for a long moment, then stepped closer, placed her hand on its trunk, and asked softly, testing the words: "Celine?"

The small tree did not speak. Only the drooping branches at the edge of its crown swayed in the wind.

The whisper that had reached her ears just now felt like a mere illusion. At her fingertips there was only the rough, hard texture of bark.

Even so, Nina could not help imagining how that elf maiden, who had led her and Mr. Morris on such a long journey and had been so excited to “go home” in the mists of the Wall of Silence, had walked all the way across the edge of the forest and through that curtain of light. She pictured Celine coming to the border of this land of ash, to this place where she could gaze upon Atlantis’s remains, and quietly becoming a tree.

“Nina, look over here.”

Morris’s voice suddenly came from not far away, breaking off her wandering thoughts.

Nina snapped back to herself at once. She hurried to Morris’s side and looked in the direction her teacher was pointing.

More small trees came into her view. At the edge of the giant tree’s remains, along the line between the land of ash and dust and the forest, on this border of Doomsday, one little tree after another stood in rows, as if they were guarding that field of ash and ruin.

Or perhaps they were guarding the lush forest the dream had drawn beyond the ruins.

The whole area around the ruins was filled with countless nameless little trees.

A breeze blew. The small trees swung their branches and made a very faint sound that left one unsure whether it was the wind or the trees themselves.

Nina stared blankly at the scene. After who knew how long, she could not help murmuring to herself: “So many… Are all of these Celine…”

Morris did not speak. The old scholar only watched quietly as the small trees ringed Atlantis's remains. Then, as if something had occurred to him, he walked up a nearby rise of earth and looked back toward the direction he and Nina had come from, toward the vast forest in the distance.

Mist drifted out of the dense forest and mixed with the ash and dust over the plain, sketching out a hazy "border".

He came down from the rise with a thoughtful look on his face and walked over to Nina.

Nina noticed the expression on her teacher's face. "Mr. Morris, did you find something?"

"…I have a bold guess, 'Celine' is the Wall of Silence." Morris spoke in a low voice.

Nina stared, a little stunned.

"Atlantis created the Wall of Silence and gave it the mission of sheltering the elves. But that was an impossible task. And it seems that from the very beginning Atlantis, as the Creator, knew this. Even so, the Wall of Silence has been carrying out that order all along," Morris said, his expression serious. "I just observed the edge of the forest and confirmed that those 'nameless little trees' are all arranged along the line between the forest and the ruins. There is a faint pattern in how they are placed, like some kind of array, not a random natural spread. That is the mark of careful design."

"Then…" Nina hesitated, then could not help asking, "But we are not elves…"

"But this is not the real Atlantis or the 'primordial dream', either," Morris said, shaking his head. "Don't forget, this is only the Nameless One's dream."

Nina froze for a moment at his words, then quickly understood the deeper meaning behind them.

This was only the Nameless One’s dream.

The era the elves’ Elder Gods had described, the time of the Great Demon God Saslokar who created worlds in the dream, and the World Tree Atlantis that sheltered the elves in that dream, had truly existed long before the era of the Deep Sea.

That age had long since ended, in the Great Annihilation.

What now appeared in Lightwind Harbor was only a massive series of manifestations caused by the Sun’s malfunction and the approach of “dusk”, an “echo” that seemed to be left in the racial memory of the elves.

Within this “echo”, Atlantis and the Wall of Silence would treat every individual who entered this forest with goodwill as an “elf”.

Because the elves had died many, many years ago, long before any sapient races other than elves appeared in this world.

“So what do we do next?” Nina asked.

Morris did not answer right away. Instead he calmed himself and reached out to the Captain in the depths of his mind. He reported everything that had happened here and then waited patiently.

…

Duncan was a little stunned.

He was still with Agatha in the hold of the “Vanished in the dream”, studying that massive Elder God spine. He hoped to find more useful information there related to the Great Demon God Saslokar, or to dig out more secrets about the Vanished itself.

He had not expected that, in the short time when he was not paying attention, Morris and Nina’s team would pull off something this earthshaking.

They had pierced the Wall of Silence, seen the truth inside it, and even seen Atlantis, which had already become a field of remains.

Duncan felt a strange unreality in his daze.

The “Witch” and the illiterate squad were still wandering around in the forest. The Athlete was still struggling alone in the desert. The Historian had already taken his Student to the middle of the map and dug up an Elder God’s grave.

It felt like sending out two investigators at the start of a game and then, three turns later, finding Cthulhu already lying dead on the doorstep.

Duncan shook his head and pushed these sudden wild thoughts aside for the moment.

Morris was still waiting for his instructions.

He lifted his head and looked at the space around him, filled with dark mist.

Saslokar’s spine stretched out beneath his feet. This shattered Elder God seemed to be using it to send him some kind of message. Even the Vanished, built atop that Elder God spine, seemed to be doing its best to show him its “memories”.

Duncan let out a slow breath.

“Approach that ‘ruin’,” he said in his heart. “Investigate Atlantis.”

Chapter 618: Rabby and Little Doll

Several figures in dark coats or hooded robes were moving through the depths of the dense forest.

A faint black dust hung around them. Black symbiotic pact chains stretched out from their bodies. Savage Abyssal demons walked at their sides. Richard and his “brethren” had already been acting in this dream for some time, and according to what the Death-Omen Bird sensed, they were now very close to the “Wall of Silence”.

But the group suddenly stopped.

The mood in the forest had changed in a subtle way. At some point, a thin mist had begun to rise from nowhere, curling through the clearings between the trees. As the mist appeared, the whole forest became even more… “silent” than before.

Dumont frowned. He remembered that when they had first entered the dream of the Nameless One, this forest had still been full of sounds. Unknown birds beat their wings and took off. Unknown beasts roared in the distance. They had never been able to see those birds or beasts, but all those sounds of life had always been there.

Now those sounds had vanished. Only the occasional wind and the faint rustle of swaying leaves remained, making the silence feel even deeper.

Any change in the Nameless One’s dream had to be treated with great care.

“These mists feel a bit wrong,” another Annihilator said softly. A jellyfish like drifting smoke floated in the air beside him. The tentacles that hung beneath it twitched in small, uneasy movements. “My demon senses fear and tension… It is the emotion this ‘forest’ itself is releasing.”

“The Nameless One’s dream does have emotional shifts. It is itself a vast mind,” Dumont said in a low voice. “If its mood suddenly changed, it may mean someone reached the core of that mind… Could someone have found the ‘Wall of Silence’?”

“Would it be our people?” the Annihilator who had a symbiotic pact with the Smokewisp Jellyfish asked.

“We are not sure yet. We cannot reach the other brethren the chapter sent into this place,” Dumont said. Then he frowned and looked toward a figure at the back of the group. That person had been scratching at himself the whole time. “Richard, what are you doing?”

Richard started as if waking from a dream. He realized he had been scratching the skin around his neck and his waist. Puzzled, he raised his hand and saw many tiny white fibers caught under his nails. They looked like…

“Cotton,” he whispered.

“Cotton? What cotton?” Dumont frowned. “You do not seem quite right.”

“No, I am fine,” Richard said at once. He lifted his head and patted down his clothes, which he had mussed up by scratching. “I just feel a little itchy. This mist makes me uncomfortable.”

Dumont nodded and did not press the matter. Instead, he turned his gaze to the others: “We should already be within the influence of the Wall of Silence. According to those so?called ‘Preachers’, this is the ‘gaze’ zone of

Atlantis’s mind. If you see or hear anything that was not present in the forest before, you must tell the others at once.”

Listening to his voice, Richard felt a dull irritation in his chest.

Dumont had already started to lead the team with the air of a leader. That arrogant, self?important attitude had always been unpleasant… The group did need someone to give orders, but that role should have been his.

“It really makes one angry…” A light little voice spoke in Richard’s mind. “Rabby thinks this is very unfair. Rabby feels sorry for you…”

“It really is unfair,” Richard muttered under his breath, moving his lips so that only he could hear. “But this is the Saint’s arrangement… and Dumont is indeed capable…”

“Is the most important reason not that all these troublesome people are watching you?” the voice in his head whispered, in a tone of tender concern and easy trust. “If no one were watching, then none of this would be troublesome at all…”

Richard frowned and slowly shook his head, sensing on instinct that something was not quite right. He still hesitated: “But… what should I do…?”

“Be patient. Be a little patient, my lovely Little Doll. Rabby is only telling you about some possibilities. It is not the time yet… The chance will come, when someone is left alone…”

Richard covered his forehead, torn with doubt: “But I cannot… they are all my brethren…”

“Yes, they are all your brethren, my lovely Little Doll. You must not hurt them. Rabby does not wish to see you harm one another—so you have to help them instead.”

“Help them? How do I help them?”

“Have you not noticed? Your brethren… their bellies are empty. They do not even have cotton inside them. How pitiful. No cotton, no warmth. No cotton, no soul. No cotton, nothing at all… You already have cotton, my lovely Little Doll. Give them some cotton too. Rabby can lend you cotton, as long as you… remember to give it back…”

The small, sweet voice in his mind slowly faded away.

Richard blinked and suddenly felt confused. He thought he had just heard someone speaking to him, and even remembered holding a conversation. But with a single moment of distraction, the voice was gone, as if… it had all been an illusion.

He lifted his head and looked at Dumont ahead of him and at the other brethren around him.

How pitiful they were.

“…We will set mark points here,” Dumont said, apparently not noticing Richard’s gaze. He had already begun to assign the next steps according to the plan. “From here, we can already affect the lower layers of Atlantis’s mind. It is a suitable area for deployment.”

The cultists around them all nodded. Then each of them took out the tool used for the ritual—a strange little knife, black as pitch, with a curved blade.

Richard paused for a moment, then reached into his coat as well and felt his own bone shard knife.

It was a small carving knife, only the size of his palm, made from some blackened bone. Strange, intricate patterns covered its surface, and it gave off an ominous air.

Richard remembered that the raw material for this knife came from the bones left behind by Abyssal demons whose summoning rituals had failed. Not every summoning and symbiotic pact ritual succeeded. The failures became nourishment on the altar. Those Annihilators who lacked talent washed the altar with their blood, and the demons that died in a ritual runaway state left behind bone shards that could be used to make tools.

This ought to have been basic common sense for every Annihilator who had advanced to the priest rank. Yet for some reason, when Richard recalled this knowledge now, he felt a strange… sense of novelty.

He shook his head and pushed that odd feeling aside, then looked toward Dumont: “We have to set as many Marks as possible before this dream ends. If we split up, it might be more efficient.”

“…Splitting up means danger,” Dumont said after thinking over the suggestion. He shook his head. “Do not forget your previous failure—brethren who acted alone had almost no power to fight back when they faced His followers.”

Dumont really seemed to be giving a serious warning, with no mockery in his words. Yet Richard felt he saw a hint of scorn in the other man’s eyes, and anger flared up inside him like poison fire.

He felt he had been deeply humiliated.

Yet the next second, that rage like poison fire suddenly went out and was replaced by an icy calm. Richard was surprised at how cool?headed he could be.

He looked at Dumont with an unusually sincere, steady expression, and his words carried a quiet power of persuasion: “Of course we cannot move alone. I mean groups of two or three. That way we can watch each other and still finish the task quickly. And to be honest, even if we do meet those

followers and fall into a disadvantage, we can still withdraw from this dream at once. From what I observed last time, those followers do not seem able to come and go in the dream as freely as we do…”

The earnest look on Richard’s face and the calm steadiness in his tone had their effect.

Dumont began to think it over again.

Here was a fellow believer with much Dreamwalking experience. Though his condition had not been very good since the last exploration, his proposal now was clearly well considered and trustworthy, and every reason he gave was sound.

If he kept ignoring or rejecting this advice, it would make him look as if he were deliberately targeting someone experienced. Coming across as petty and narrow?minded would do nothing to help him lead the team.

Dumont felt he ought to accept the suggestion. As a new, half?unspoken leader, accepting advice was also part of building his authority.

Besides, if anything truly went wrong later, the responsibility would be Richard’s.

“Very well. Then we will go in pairs and set mark points along the edge of the mist,” Dumont said with a nod, quickly giving orders. Then he looked at Richard. “Richard, you are with me.”

“Of course,” Richard said with a smile, as if he were very pleased with this arrangement.

Dumont was pleased as well.

“Then let us move out.”

The Annihilators moved at once.

They split into pairs, each carrying the ritual dagger used to leave Marks. The pairs headed off in different directions along the forest paths where the thin mist flowed, and soon vanished into the depths of the woods.

Richard took his own ritual dagger and walked toward Dumont. But he was careful. He knew he still had to wait. He had to wait until the other pairs were far enough away, and until Dumont's attention was fixed on the "work" of setting a mark.

Then he could "help" Dumont.

"Let us begin, my lovely Little Doll," the voice in his mind said.

"Let us begin, Dumont," Richard said.

Chapter 619: The Hunt and the Phantom

The small knife, carved from black bone shards, drew a shallow cut across the rough bark, leaving an inconspicuous mark on the trunk of the towering tree. Then blood was smeared over it to pour spirit and blood power into it—each mark had to be painted with blood three times, again and again…

Richard followed his memory as he worked, carving Marks. With the bone shard knife in his hand, he etched runes that symbolized the power of the Abyssal Deep into the tree trunks and smeared his own blood over them. Then he lifted his head and looked at Dumont, who was doing the same thing not far away.

He walked over, as if he meant to speak to him.

“Each mark is weak on its own,” Dumont said casually when he saw Richard come closer. “But if there are enough of them, they will exert a strong enough influence on Atlantis.”

“Still not enough… far from enough…” Richard muttered vaguely, turning the little bone shard knife between his fingers without thinking.

“It is true that these Marks alone are not enough. But once the process begins, it will only speed up. When Atlantis ‘remembers’ that day, that will be the time to reap the fruit,” Dumont said with a smile, seeming full of confidence in the future. “Those so?called Preachers may not be reliable, but at least this time the information they gave us was useful.”

Richard did not answer. He only lifted his head, staring up at the big tree where Dumont had just left a mark, as if he were quietly admiring the scenery. He looked so intent that Dumont also raised his head without thinking, glancing in puzzlement at the crown of the tree.

“What are you looking at? Is there some—”

Richard suddenly lifted his arm in a pose and at an angle no human joints should ever have been able to make—almost as if his right arm had been folded into three pieces. His hand swung in through Dumont’s blind spot, and he drove the bone shard knife hard into Dumont’s chest.

But the little knife used for the ritual was meant to kill the Undying, so this blow only pierced his skin.

A sharp stab of pain burst from his chest. The sudden, senseless attack left Dumont’s mind blank for a heartbeat, but then he reacted. He slapped Richard’s arm away, clutched his wound with one hand, and leaped back.

Black chains flashed into view, and a hideous Abyssal Hound appeared at Dumont’s back. But before the hound could move, the Death-Omen Bird on Richard’s shoulder dove down. Its great skeletal wings stretched and twisted like shackles, and in an instant they wrapped around the hound. With a chorus of creaking, grinding bone, the two demons tangled together, locked in a struggle that could not quickly be broken.

“Are you mad?!” Dumont stared, eyes wide, at Richard, who was standing not far away with a blank face. “You are trying to kill me?!”

“No,” Richard said, shaking his head. He glanced at the Abyssal Hound that the Death-Omen Bird held in check. A strange, hard?to?name disgust flickered over his face, but he still spoke to Dumont very earnestly. “I only want to help you.”

“Help me?” Dumont was stunned. He looked at Richard as if he were looking at a madman, yet a heavy confusion welled up inside him. The ritual knife was meant to kill the Undying; that sudden strike had only managed to cut him. He honestly did not know how he ought to react. Only one thing was certain: Richard was not in his right mind.

Richard nodded solemnly. “Yes, help you. Your body is empty. I have to help you fill it with cotton. That will make you better.”

“…Cotton?” Dumont repeated the strange word in a daze. “What nonsense are you talking…”

He stopped mid?sentence.

He felt an itch at the spot on his chest where the knife had pierced him.

The faint itch quickly turned into a strange feeling he could not ignore, as if something were growing there, squirming there.

He scratched the itchy spot without thinking. Then he forgot to keep watching the clearly unstable Richard and lowered his head to look at his wound.

The blood had already stopped. On his clothes, stained with a little red, he could just make out some white fluff. The fluff was slowly spreading, as if… it were being formed by the blood itself changing.

After a brief hesitation, Dumont pulled open his collar. He saw the tiny wound closing. Between the writhing, shrinking flesh, cotton was slowly working its way into his body.

The Death-Omen Bird and the Abyssal Hound, still locked together, slowly ceased their struggle. The dull?witted demons knew nothing of hatred or anger; their actions were ruled by the emotions and understanding of the ones bound to them by the symbiotic pact. As the skeletal wings folded away, the two demons returned to their respective masters.

Dumont lifted his head and gave Richard a peculiar look. He remembered that their relationship had never been very good, especially in recent times. They did not have any great enmity, but small frictions between them were common.

That was exactly why, when he had decided they would split into pairs, he had asked to keep Richard with him—he did not want Richard pulling any "little tricks" out of his sight.

He had never imagined that this fellow would do something like this to him.

After hesitating for a long time, Dumont finally spoke, sounding awkward: "You are… surprisingly kind."

Richard smiled. In that moment, the trivial rift between him and Dumont vanished—cotton had mended the brotherly bond between him and his fellow.

"We should help the others as well," Richard said earnestly. "Everyone is hollow inside. They all need cotton."

"Yes, everyone needs cotton…" Dumont still was not used to this new self, and his expression was a little stiff as he spoke, but he agreed with Richard's idea. "We can start with Sariel's group. He is an honest, hardworking man."

"No problem, but we need a plan. People without cotton are not rational. They may not yet understand how important cotton is—just like you a moment ago. We must think carefully about how they will react…"

"Yes. Rabby also thinks you need a plan…"

"We can discuss it as we walk."

"Then let us set out." "Set out." "Set out."

Richard and Dumont lifted their heads at the same time and looked down the mist?shrouded forest path. Then they stepped forward and walked toward the foggy depths of the dream.

Rabby went hunting.

…

The ground, covered in ash and black cinders, creaked underfoot and always felt as if it might collapse at any moment. Fallen, broken branches lay crisscrossed everywhere, more troublesome than undergrowth and vines in any forest.

Nina and Morris moved with difficulty through this vast tangle of wreckage, which seemed to stretch on without end. After a long time, they were still only skirting its outer edge.

“This is even harder to walk through than the forest outside,” Nina grumbled. “At least the forest has little paths trampled out by wild animals… Here it is all ash that your foot sinks into with every step.”

As she spoke, she lifted her foot out of the ash and cinders. Her filthy shoe made her frown.

She steadied herself against a charred branch, pulled off her left shoe, and shook it hard. Several bits of stone and black grit fell out.

“And I feel as if we have been circling the edge of this scorched ground the whole time,” she went on. “Can we really find a way into the center of the wreckage like this?”

“The collapsed crown of the tree is blocking the path to Atlantis’s main trunk… It is troublesome indeed,” Morris said, frowning as he looked at the jagged, overlapping black branches in the distance.

They called them branches, but their size was already beyond what “branch” should mean. The broken limbs that had fallen from the top of the World Tree were truly gigantic. Even the twigs that were small only by comparison were often a hundred meters long, with diameters close to that of a tower. They had crashed down in a tangled heap over this scorched land, forming a structure so huge it was frightening. From a distance, it looked less like a mass of charred deadwood and more like… a gigantic city that had collapsed from the clouds.

With such a mountain of “fallen leaves and twigs” in front of them, trying to force their way through with brute strength was simply not something mortals could do. The only choice was to go around and around, or risk squeezing into the gaps between branches to look for narrow paths that the ash had not yet completely choked off.

“If Miss Vanna were here, she might just charge straight through,” Nina muttered when that thought of “brute force” crossed her mind. “All this wreckage in the way would not be able to block even one of her punches.”

“Vanna does not rely on brute strength alone,” Morris, who had known Vanna for many years as her elder, could not help saying. “And even she, facing something like this, would probably…”

He stopped halfway through his sentence, seeming to hesitate.

A moment later, he shook his head. “Very well, perhaps not. She might really be able to do it.”

“Actually, I could do it too…” Nina muttered under her breath.

Morris gave the young lady a look, as if he wanted to say something. But just as he was about to speak, a light breeze swept over the ashen ground. Dust billowed up, and through the sudden haze he and Nina both saw a vague shadow flicker not far ahead.

It looked like someone standing blankly in the wind… an elf?

Nina froze for an instant, then quickly turned her head. “Mr. Morris, did you just see over there—”

“I saw it,” Morris said before Nina could finish, his expression turning serious. “It looked like an elf.”

“It did not look like Celine…” Nina said, uncertain. “The way it was dressed was more like… more like…”

She hesitated, unable to draw a conclusion for the moment, but Morris gave a slight nod.

“Like a resident of Lightwind Harbor.”

Chapter 620: the sunlight Today Was So Nice

In the ruins of Atlantis, in the wind that suddenly blew across the scorched ground, a phantom appeared that looked like a modern Lightwind Harbor resident.

Nina and Morris both saw the phantom—it was clearly not an illusion.

“There is nothing here…” Morris walked to the spot where the phantom had just appeared, carefully checked the surroundings, and said in a low voice with a frown.

The sudden incident made Nina a little nervous too. She instinctively lowered her voice: “Why did that one just now look like a ghost…”

Morris gave this young lady a strange look: “Do you need to be afraid of ghosts?”

“…Right.”

Nina muttered this only after the fact, and the moment her voice faded, something else suddenly appeared at the edge of her vision.

It was another “phantom”. It appeared in the wind and dust, flashed past between the huge blackened ruins woven from branches. In that brief instant, Nina felt as if she had seen the person’s face clearly… she even felt that face looked a bit familiar.

It looked like the owner of that clothing shop in the western district of Lightwind Harbor, an elf lady who always wore a smile—she appeared in the wind with a blank face, then scattered with the wind again.

“Over here!” Nina reacted at once, grabbed Morris, and ran toward where the second phantom had appeared. Before they even reached that spot, Nina saw something else seem to flash through the mist in the distance.

Phantoms, phantoms of elves, began to appear again and again between the wind and dust. As Nina and Morris went deeper into the ruins, the phantoms appeared more and more often. At first they only flickered past the edges of their vision now and then. Later, no matter which way they looked, they could see one or two hazy figures, like ghosts, flickering in and out of the air.

Without noticing, Nina had already widened her eyes. She and Morris walked across the scorched ground that was covered in ash and black cinders, moving between the huge wreckage of Atlantis. Around them, “Lightwind Harbor residents” wearing modern clothes kept appearing and fading like unstable ghosts. These phantoms wore blank expressions and drifted aimlessly through the dust. They had no reaction at all to Nina and Morris drawing near, and they carried a… chilling feeling.

At last, Nina and Morris stopped in a wide open space.

Phantoms were everywhere around them, phantoms of elves. Mixed in among them were some shadows whose outlines were so vague their race could not be told. Near and far, real and unreal tangled together, flickering in and out. Chaotic winds raised sand and dust, blew through these hollow ghosts, blew through the vast, broken canopy of Atlantis. Under the dim, turbid sky, countless phantoms gathered in the ruins of this legendary “World Tree”, like a strange and horrifying… wraith gathering.

“This time I really am starting to get a little scared…” Nina nervously tugged at the hem of her clothes. The air around her twisted slightly, and hot radiance flickered in her eyes from time to time. “Are these really all the elves from Lightwind Harbor… I even saw that uncle at the corner of Crown Street who sells ‘elf wraps’. He puts that stinking rotten organ meat sauce in the wraps…”

As soon as the words left her mouth, she nervously glanced at that phantom not far away—because she still remembered that whenever she described “elf wraps” like that, that uncle would immediately get very angry and serious and correct her, saying it was actually “a pure traditional sauce with four thousand years of history”. The look on his face would be quite scary.

Yet that phantom simply faded quietly, just like the other phantoms that kept appearing and vanishing around them.

Nina turned her head and looked at Morris: “…Could all the people who disappear from Lightwind Harbor every night be here? Are they all inside the ‘Wall of Silence’?”

Morris had not spoken since just now. He only frowned as he looked around, a thoughtful look on his face. After a moment he suddenly broke the silence: “Atlantis is ‘protecting’ them.”

Nina did not understand at once: “Huh?”

“This is Atlantis’s ‘protection’,” Morris seemed to have figured some things out. “She is trying to ‘gather’ the minds of all the elves to the inner side of the Wall of Silence. She firmly believes this can protect them when the world’s Doomsday comes.”

The old scholar paused here. After a brief thought he went on: “Under normal conditions, every elf who enters the Nameless One’s dream should be teleported directly to this place and become one of the phantoms here.

But the few of us are exceptions. The captain's power lets us stay clear-headed in the dream. That is why 'Celine' appeared to us—Atlantis thinks we are elves who have lost our way outside."

Nina listened in stunned silence, but she quickly understood what her teacher said, and her instincts told her this was probably the truth.

But this could not explain what Miss Vanna had run into—that desert, and that giant who claimed to be a "God", what were those about?

Besides that question, Nina immediately thought of another, even more critical problem.

"Then if the minds of all these elves are trapped in Atlantis's ruins every night… won't something go wrong if this goes on for long?!"

"Of course it will," Morris said, his expression grave. "Outside Lightwind Harbor, a condition called Sleep Sickness has already started to spread among elf residents of other city-states. Inside Lightwind Harbor, the dream's corruption has already begun to leave marks in the Mortal Realm. If this kind of 'protection' keeps going… something big is bound to happen."

Nina opened her mouth, as if she wanted to say something more, but right then the wind and dust rose again before her eyes, and a new phantom appeared in front of her.

It was a middle-aged man whose hair was dry and messy, whose beard looked as if it had not been shaved for days. He looked sloppy and tired. As an elf, a member of a race stamped with "healthy, long-lived, and elegant" as basic traits, that appearance instead gave people the feeling that his health was already at the limit, as if he might drop dead at any time.

Nina recognized this phantom at a glance.

“It is Master Taran Ael,” she said in surprise as she looked at Taran Ael, whose face was blank and who was just as dazed and frozen as the other phantoms. Even though she had already seen other “acquaintances” here a moment ago, seeing this elf scholar still caught her off guard. “He appeared here too…”

“It seems everyone who disappears during the Nameless One’s dream will appear here. That is not surprising,” Morris said calmly. As he spoke, he walked up to Taran Ael’s phantom and looked at him with a slight frown. “The key is to figure out what state these elves in the ‘dreamwalking’ phase are in. They seem to have formed an ever more stable link with Atlantis. It is unlikely we can wake them easily…”

Nina also came closer. She braced herself and poked Master Taran Ael’s arm with a finger: “I remember Mr. Ael was trapped in a dream once before. What method did he use then to wake himself up and save himself…”

Taran Ael’s phantom suddenly blinked.

Nina thought she had seen wrong and lifted her head to look again.

Taran Ael slowly turned his head and shifted his gaze onto her.

Nina: “…”

The next second, a huge fireball rose into the sky above the ruins of Atlantis.

A shocking shockwave shattered the chaotic clouds in the sky. The chaotic winds circling the remains of the World Tree froze for an instant. The terrifying fireball rose like a new star and, in just a few seconds, turned the whole scorched land as bright as day!

But the fireball did not explode directly on the ruins of Atlantis or on the “phantoms” wandering within the ruins.

Her usual hard training showed its effect. At the critical moment, Nina raised her head to the sky—her scream turned into the roar of the Sun. The spewing stellar matter only created a temporary Sun high above the Nameless One's dream that lasted a few seconds. In the grand Coronal Blast, the damage was held to a minimum.

But even such a brief impact sparked a reaction from the Nameless One's dream at once. The forests close to the Wall of Silence howled as they grew madly. The ground trembled under the Sun's light as if it were about to boil. Distant mountains rumbled, and it seemed that if it had lasted even one second longer, Atlantis would have awakened under this otherworldly sunlight. Yet as the fireball in the sky faded, the Nameless One's dream still calmed down at the edge of collapse.

Inside the ruins of Atlantis, the huge cloud of dust raised by the shockwave in the sky had not yet settled when a dusty figure crawled out of a heap of ash—Morris. He slapped the dust hard off his clothes, shook black cinders out of his hair, then dug at his ears before finally lifting his head to glare at Nina: "How many times has the captain told you, stop jumping straight to blowing things up every time you get a scare!"

Nina's whole body still shone with golden sunlight, and she herself had not completely cooled down. Hearing her teacher Morris's words, she scratched her face in embarrassment. Before she could speak, Taran Ael's still-shaken voice came from the side: "Is that how you use 'get scared then blow up'?"

Morris's beard bristled as he glared, his face full of annoyance: "Just say whether it blew up or not!"

It was no easy thing to make this usually refined and calm old scholar lose his composure like this. It was the first time Nina had seen her teacher almost jump up and curse. But compared to this small matter, what shocked her more was Master Taran Ael beside them.

This elf scholar, who a moment ago had only been a dazed phantom, had now turned into a vivid and lively “mind entity”. He stood in the swirling dust. Though the recent impact of the Sun had left him rather disheveled, he was clearly completely awake now.

This Grand Scholar was staring blankly at Nina, who was still glowing, his eyes full of lingering shock.

Clearly, having the Sun blow up in his face the instant he woke up was a bit too much stimulation for a middle-aged man in poor health.

Chapter 621: “Assembly”

The sunlight around Nina finally faded bit by bit. She walked toward Taran Ael in doubt and surprise, as if she was still trying to confirm whether this elf scholar had really “woken up” from his hazy phantom state. After looking him up and down several times, she tested the waters and said: “Mr. Ael, you really woke up?”

But Taran Ael did not answer her. He only frowned slightly, and his face did not look good.

This made Nina suspect for a moment that the fireball explosion just now had been a bit too strong, and this Grand Scholar’s ears had not recovered yet.

But a few seconds later, Taran Ael suddenly reacted. He waved a hand at Nina in a bit of a panic, then rushed to the side and bent over, starting to retch violently.

Nina jumped in fright but did not know what to do. She could only step up and pat this Grand Scholar on the back. When he finally got a little better, she spoke, tense and embarrassed: “Sorry, I must have blown you silly…”

“No… that is not the reason,” Taran Ael said, gasping for breath as he waved his hand hard. Nina’s attempt at concern almost made him choke again. After almost half a minute of panting, this elf scholar finally straightened his back and explained with a pained look: “It is probably the medicine.”

Nina froze when she heard this: “Medicine? What medicine?”

“The medicine that lets me ‘wake up’ in this dream,” Taran Ael said. His breathing had evened out, and he was thumping his chest with his fist as he spoke. “Only I woke up? Did you see anyone else?”

Morris was walking over from the side at this moment. Hearing this, he frowned without thinking: “There are others? What exactly is going on?”

Taran Ael glanced at Morris, then subconsciously looked around at this strange, unfamiliar place. He was clearly still a bit dazed, but he still began to explain earnestly: “Lord Ted Lier, Truth Keeper, organized a small team. I served as the team’s advisor—we gathered before the dream began and drank the ‘Blood Raven’ elixir…”

“Blood Raven Elixir?!” Morris was startled at once. He looked at the man in front of him in disbelief. “Isn’t that a bit reckless on your part?”

Nina did not understand what they were talking about and could not help asking: “Mr. Morris, what is it? What is the Blood Raven Elixir?”

“A kind of magic potion, extracted from several poisonous fungi. Very dangerous,” Morris explained. “It acts directly on the mind. After a delayed effect, it can put a person into a state like death, letting spirit and flesh separate and their senses go out of place. It is used to help read extremely dangerous ‘knowledge’. The people who drink it can, in that sleeping fake death, avoid the deadly stages of corruption or the curse. But because the elixir itself is too dangerous, only after strict review by the Academy, with tight safety preparations and confirmation that it is truly necessary, will the Truth Academy allow such an elixir to be brewed and drunk.”

The old scholar explained this, then could not help glancing at Taran Ael again: “I still have to say it again… isn’t that a bit reckless on your part?”

“But it worked very well. My guess was proven—so long as we force a rather strong case of ‘mental misalignment’, we can wake up inside the

Nameless One’s dream, just like a punch-card machine will automatically spit out paper tape that does not meet the standard,” Taran Ael said, spreading his hands. “Of course, the other possibility was that we would be ‘ejected’ directly from the Nameless One’s dream and return to the Mortal Realm. But now it seems… the power of this dream is even greater than we imagined. Even a fake death on the level of the mind can only let us regain clarity inside the dream. If we want to leave this dream, we may still need some other way of shocking ourselves…”

He deliberately paused here, a proud look appearing on his face.

“An advanced application of the ‘Sudden-Death Method’—I was the one who came up with this idea.”

Morris stared, dumbfounded, at this Grand Scholar who was as famous as himself. After holding it in for a long time, he finally squeezed out one sentence: “…How did Lord Truth Keeper agree to a plan like that from you?”

“He did think there were problems with my plan,” Taran Ael shrugged. “But I told him that although the matter was serious, we should still put safety first, so he finally agreed to start with a more conservative plan…”

Morris: “…?”

He had always thought he was already quite radical on the path of scholarly research. Only now did he suddenly realize that in Lightwind Harbor, this elf city-state near the border, the elves who faced the “frontier fields” every day were even bolder.

“Don’t make that face, Morris. I actually know what you are worried about. We are doing something very dangerous, and this does not really fit the code of conduct for a ‘scholar’,” Taran Ael said. He had noticed the change

in Morris’s expression, and at last he put away his smile and grew serious. “But we may not have many choices left.

“You have probably already gotten the news. A condition called ‘Sleep Sickness’ is spreading in other city-states. It is clearly tied to the growth of the Nameless One’s dream. And outside my laboratory, a tree that has drilled from the dream into the Mortal Realm is using its crown to cover my roof and balcony…

“So it is time to do some risky things, because this world does not seem to plan on giving us the time to get fully ready.”

Morris fell silent.

Taran Ael once more studied the surroundings. After a moment, he shook his head: “It seems the first thing I have to do here is find the others.”

“The good news is that you should all be within the scope of these ruins. The bad news is that the scope of these ruins is huge,” Morris sighed. “Now I will tell you the first bit of experience for moving in this dream—during a first ‘dreamwalking’, even if you and your companions are in the same room in the Mortal Realm, after you start dreamwalking you will still be scattered at random.”

Taran Ael looked at Morris, and at Nina, who was standing honestly behind Morris.

He did not see the captain’s other followers.

But it was obvious that these “Lost Home followers”, who had already acted several times in the Nameless One’s dream, had gathered a lot of experience with this vast dream.

“I need more guidance.” Taran Ael looked seriously at the two people before him.

…

“What was that just now?!”

In the forest outside the Wall of Silence, a black-robed Annihilator raised his head toward the sky, watching that intense light fade with startled doubt. After a long time he could not help crying out softly.

Yet his companion in the same group could not answer the question either —another Annihilator was also staring in shock in the same direction, unable to make a sound for a long time.

Just now, a huge fireball had risen from deep in the forest. It was definitely not something that should appear in the Nameless One’s dream. It almost shone over the forest like another Sun, tearing apart all the clouds. Its intense light seemed enough to pierce time and space, and in the light and shock of that fireball’s blast, the whole forest had a moment of “restless agitation”.

Plants had grown madly, the ground had shaken, and inexplicable howls had come out of nowhere in the air.

It was as frightening as when a “corruption phenomenon” broke out.

But this terrifying anomalous phenomenon lasted only a few seconds. Before the forest could undergo some irreversible great change, the fireball disappeared as suddenly as it had appeared.

It only left the two Annihilators, who had been carefully setting “marks” a minute earlier, staring at each other in the forest.

After who knew how long, the cultist who had first cried out finally broke the silence again: “That did not look like Atlantis awakening… it was not quite like how those preachers described it.”

“Then it might be some kind of external force…” the other one said, unconsciously lowering his voice. “That huge fireball… could it be those Suntists making trouble?”

“It shouldn’t be. The Saint is watching those Suntists’s every move. They should not suddenly do something that far out of line… And besides, even if they really are going to tear things open in the end, they would not be unable to hold back this early, right? The ‘final moment’ hasn’t come yet.”

The two Annihilators muttered uneasily. After a while longer, they finally, without planning it, thought of the same possibility.

“Could it be…” one of them began, his tone hesitant and uneasy, “could it be his followers again?”

“‘His’?”

“You know who I mean.”

“…What kind of joke is that?” The other Annihilator’s voice grew more tense at once. “That kind of commotion… that kind of commotion…”

He held it in for a long time before finally forcing out the second half: “What kind of monster would have to make a commotion like that… We aren’t really going to have to fight something like that, are we?”

Even cultists who followed the Abyssal Deep seemed to finally feel a trace of fear when faced with a power they could not understand.

But just then, the sound of footsteps suddenly came from deeper in the forest, cutting off the two cultists’ talk.

The two of them turned their heads sharply like startled birds toward the source of the sound, but when they saw the figures that appeared, they let out a sudden breath of relief.

They were their comrades.

It was Dumont, Richard, and the others who had split up earlier to set marks throughout the forest.

“Did you see that huge fireball that appeared in the sky just now?” one of the two could not help saying. “Could that have been the followers of that ghost captain?”

“We saw it. It was indeed very impressive,” Dumont nodded. His voice was as always, carrying a calm that made those around him believe him. “But don’t worry. We will not run into that power. We will all be very safe from here on.”

The two Annihilators looked at each other without thinking.

“Are we getting ready to pull out?” one of them asked Dumont. “It looks like everyone has gathered.”

“Yes, everyone has gathered,” Dumont said with a smile. He walked forward slowly, leading everyone to walk forward with him. “You were the last ones.”

Chapter 622: Howling Shadows

In the area of the World Tree's ruins, now covered in ash and black cinders, Morris, Nina, and Taran Ael had already found several knowledge guardians who had woken from the phantoms.

Just as Morris had predicted, these knowledge guardians, who had in effect just taken their first Dreamwalk, had been scattered to random places across the ruins of Atlantis. Luckily, most of them had not been thrown too far apart. Nina's fireball rising into the sky was very eye-catching, and the scattered knowledge guardians had all come to check it out. That let them regroup quickly.

All except one.

"We still haven't found Lord Ted Lier," a knowledge guardian in a short robe, holding a book and a revolver, came back to their temporary camp and said to Taran Ael, Morris, and the others who were waiting there. "I didn't see the agreed-on marks, and the Aetheric Call didn't get any response."

"Could it be that he still hasn't 'woken up'?" Taran Ael frowned without thinking. "That shouldn't be… I gave him quite a large dose. Even with a Truth Keeper's body, it should have worked smoothly…"

Nina glanced at the uneasy knowledge guardian across from her, then at Taran Ael, who was frowning in thought. She hesitated, but still could not help speaking: "Then maybe the dose was too big…"

Taran Ael froze for a moment. When he reacted, he waved his hands again and again: "Impossible, impossible. I am a careful scholar. How could I

make that kind of mistake with a dosage? And Lord Ted Lier is an expert in alchemy. He knows exactly how much potion he can take…"

The more he talked, the smaller his voice became, until he finally added in a doubtful murmur: "…Probably."

Nina and Morris: "…?"

"How much Blood Raven Elixir did you give Ted Lier, exactly?" Morris could not help asking.

Taran Ael thought for a moment, then raised his hand and gestured: "About a bottle this tall…"

Morris stared at him: "…You let him down a whole bottle of the mixture in a beer bottle?! Ordinary people use a dropper for this stuff!"

"Come on, he is a Truth Keeper," Taran Ael spread his hands. "It is really hard to push him into a 'false death' level of mental dissociation. A dose that could make an ordinary person drop dead ten times over only serves to quench his thirst. What else could I do? Lord Ted Lier even purified the potion once more himself. Otherwise, he really couldn't drink that much…"

Morris listened in stunned silence. After a long moment, he muttered with a strange look on his face: "Back when I was in school, this Truth Keeper wasn't this excessive…"

"It is from teaching graduating classes," Taran Ael waved his hand. "First he drank to drown his sorrows, then he used neurotoxins to drown his sorrows. Now I don't even dare guess what he puts in his cup of water after class… Anyway, no matter what, the problem is definitely not the dose of Blood Raven Elixir."

"Lord Ted Lier might be trapped deeper in this dream, in a place even the Aetheric Call cannot reach," a knowledge guardian nearby saw the topic drifting further and further away and quickly cut in. "This place feels very

strange. When we split up to search the nearby ruins just now, we found that once we walked beyond a certain distance, we started feeling dazed. Our minds went blank, and there were even short periods of memory loss. Our Psychic Sensing of each other also became intermittent…"

"It really was like that," another knowledge guardian nodded at once. "Selanie even said that for a few seconds she completely forgot who she was, forgot everything about the Mortal Realm. She felt as if she had been born here, and wanted to stay here forever…"

Nina looked at the two speaking knowledge guardians, thought for a moment, and asked: "You are really sure this isn't because the dose was too high?"

"My dosage was absolutely fine!" Before the two guardians could answer, Taran Ael could not hold back. "Miss, please trust the value of a first-class alchemist license, and besides, I am the inventor of the 'Sudden-Death Method'. No one understands it better than I do…"

"The fact that you invented something called the 'Sudden-Death Method' is reason enough for the Truth Academy to take your license away," Morris could not help grumbling. But after thinking it over seriously, he still shook his head. "It probably has nothing to do with the side effects of the potion. What those two knowledge guardians described sounds more like the Nameless One's Dream itself affecting them."

Nina blinked as she listened: "But the two of us have been moving around in there for such a long time, and we never felt anything like that…"

Morris thought for a moment, then raised his head and looked at the distant, majestic remains of the canopy and the phantoms wandering in confusion among the ruins. "Maybe… because in the end, we are not elves."

Nina understood her teacher at once. Taran Ael and the Elven guardians around them also showed thoughtful looks.

After a short silence, Taran Ael slowly stood up. He walked onto a nearby boulder and gazed into the distance with a complicated expression.

The long stretch of charred ruins rose and fell in his view. The grand canopy had collapsed and fallen, turning into mountains and ravines on the ground. Ash covered the land, and dead branches crisscrossed through the ash.

It was like a giant city had fallen from the sky. Broken walls and shattered towers lay scattered everywhere. Bleak memories still clung to this land after its destruction, melted into the wind and drifting dust.

Taran Ael tried with all his strength to imagine what this place had once looked like.

Once there had been a forest here, a lush forest under the shade of the World Tree. The valleys and hills here had been full of life. The giant tree's roots had rippled across the earth, and clear streams had flowed through the valleys. Many living beings had dwelled here, birds, beasts, and elves.

They were his "ancestors", living in another age that he had never seen.

The lush life of that age far exceeded what people of today could imagine. But even harder to imagine than that life might be the order and peace of that time.

It was said that faraway Pland and Frostholm had already gained that kind of peace. But that "Captain Duncan" had said that even the "peace" Pland and Frostholm had now could not compare to the world before the Great Annihilation.

Taran Ael felt his imagination hit a wall.

No matter how he tried, what came to mind were not vivid scenes. Cold words seeped out of the books he had once read and into his memory, sketching only rough, vague impressions in his mind. Only with great effort, through the dream, had he finally learned what a “forest” really looked like. Yet he still could not imagine how birds and beasts had actually lived in that endless green ocean, or how the elves had formed a symbiotic pact with such a “forest”…

People always said that the elves’ ancient books and their stories passed down by word of mouth held the most complete legacy. If one day the archaeology scholars could truly restore the world as it had been before the Great Annihilation, that restored image would surely be sleeping in the libraries of Lightwind Harbor and Morka.

But now Taran Ael realized that image was already gone.

On a day long, long ago, when the seawater had swallowed this world, it had vanished together with the withering of Atlantis.

But… what had destroyed Atlantis? What had truly caused the Great Annihilation?

A blast of scorching wind suddenly blew from nowhere. The wind carried a sharp, unsettling noise, not the broken, irregular gusts that usually slipped through the ruins, but something harsher. It felt full of panic and destruction, a howl that could sweep straight through the mind.

Taran Ael snapped out of his thoughts.

The fierce howling wind almost lifted him off the ground. Taran Ael struggled to keep his footing, only to realize that at some point everything around him had sunk into darkness and chaos. It was as if all the light of the world had suddenly drawn back. The ruins of the giant tree in front of his eyes all turned into warped, uneven shadows, and huge clouds of smoke

rose from those Shadows. It looked as if the World Tree had started burning once more. The other knowledge guardians who had gathered at this resting point, as well as Morris and Nina, had all vanished from his sight.

The gale began to howl. Dark sand and dust swept across the burning World Tree. Taran Ael tumbled off the boulder in a mess, rolling several times before he finally stopped when he slammed into a giant “branch”. It was a huge limb, slightly curved like a spine. He had hit its base, and then, without thinking, he looked up at the sky.

The sky was “caving in”.

In the chaos, Taran Ael saw a scene beyond imagination.

Dim red light pierced the clouds. The dark sky was collapsing downward as if some immense thing were pressing on it. The clouds twisted, and even the light in the clouds bent. It was as if some vast Great Terror was slowly grinding down, about to flatten the whole world. The crushing pressure of that Great Terror made Taran Ael feel as if he could not breathe. Even his thoughts froze. And in that suffocating fear, he saw white floating lights.

Specks of white glimmer spread out from the burning ruins of Atlantis. They slowly gathered in the air into streams of light. The glimmers flowed between the giant branches and the scorched ground, and as if sensing something, they gradually gathered before Taran Ael.

Taran Ael’s eyes widened. He felt a warm power in that stream of light, but for some reason, great panic and unease rose in his heart at the same time. He stared at the glow until it gathered in front of him into a hazy ball of light.

The ball of light had no form, yet it seemed to have a mind. It slowly circled Taran Ael, as if curiously observing something.

Then it suddenly stopped.

Taran Ael heard a sharp, howling sound. The howl seemed ready to drill straight into his skull and bore a hole through his brain.

The voice was young, full of great terror and a kind of mad anger.

“No! You are not elves!”

Chapter 623: The Beginning of the Collapse

Taran Ael felt that young yet piercing scream almost chisel straight through his soul.

It was as if some invisible force were tearing his thoughts apart, as if a vast mind were striking his memories. That scream crossed time, space, and every layer of meaning. It echoed again and again in every stage of his life that he could remember. It lasted only a very short instant, yet the pain and chaos of it still far, far exceeded what he had felt when he drank the Blood Raven Elixir, ten times, a hundred times over.

After that, he felt the entire Nameless One’s Dream begin to collapse. The wind roared. The ground tore open. The distant ruins of the World Tree fell in on themselves at great speed. The silhouettes of forests farther away rose and curled, as if gravity itself were rolling backward. Then all of this sank into darkness in just a few seconds. Taran Ael became aware that the dream was melting away, and right after that he sensed the existence of the Mortal Realm. Light appeared at the end of that darkness, flowing and spinning on the far wall like a whirlpool before slowly settling down. Then he heard other people’s voices around him.

He woke up. He woke in the Mortal Realm, in the early morning.

Everyone was waking up.

“What happened… Why did the Nameless One’s Dream suddenly collapse?”

“I don’t know. It was like a blast of wind started… I only remember the land in the distance rolling backward…”

“Is anyone hurt? Is everyone here? What time is it now?”

People were talking nearby, sounding confused. Everything seemed to be in chaos.

Taran Ael fought against the sharp pain in his head. The effects of that scream had followed him back into the Mortal Realm. Now his headache felt so bad it was as if he really might drop dead. After that, the wildly spinning scene before his eyes finally began to steady.

He found himself sitting on a low couch in the corner by the wall. Around him, the knowledge guardians were quickly waking and trying to figure out what had happened.

Someone had already pulled open the curtains not far away. Morning sunlight was spreading along the rooftops of the city blocks. The street outside was still quiet, and only now and then came a few sounds.

Taran Ael held his forehead and slowly stood up from the corner. His thoughts were still in a mess, but after hearing the knowledge guardians talking around him, he forced himself to focus a little: “It might be related to the voice I heard at the end…”

Someone finally noticed the Grand Scholar’s awful state. A nearby knowledge guardian hurried over and caught Taran Ael just as he was about to fall: “What did you say, sir?”

“I think I may have come into contact with Atlantis’s consciousness, but…” Taran Ael frowned as he spoke. Halfway through, he suddenly stopped. He furrowed his brow and looked toward a certain spot in the room. “…Lord Ted Lier hasn’t come back?!”

The others in the room seemed to realize it only then. Several gazes instantly turned to the armchair in the middle.

It was the chair Lord Ted Lier, the Truth Keeper, had sat in when he went Dreamwalking. Now all the personnel who had gone on the Dreamwalk had returned to the Mortal Realm, but that chair was still empty.

After a brief silence, someone broke the quiet in a worried voice: "…Could the Truth Keeper have woken earlier than us and left first?"

"No. That doesn't fit the Truth Keeper's character. And there is a mark on the door. If anyone opened it, it would leave a trace, whether it was opened from outside or from inside."

Frowning as he listened to the voices beside him, Taran Ael gently pushed away the supporting hand and stepped up to the chair.

On the small table next to the chair still sat the container that had held the potion. Seven droppers and a large beer bottle rested there quietly, reflecting the rosy light spilling in from the window.

Faintly, he heard sounds from outside the window again. It seemed like chaos coming from some unknown direction.

Someone cried out in the street. Someone was running in the hallway.

Tree shadows swayed outside the window.

…

Nina jolted awake from the collapsing Nameless One's Dream. When she realized she had returned to the Mortal Realm, she could not help spacing out for a moment.

This time, the way the Nameless One's Dream ended seemed different from before.

This time it was more sudden, more violent, full of a feeling of chaos and breaking apart. It was as if the dream had not “woken up”, but had been torn open from the inside out by some force.

She raised her head and saw Mr. Morris on the other side of the table, also looking thoughtful. Clearly her teacher also felt that something was wrong with how the Nameless One’s Dream had ended this time.

Just then, she suddenly heard Shirley’s voice coming from the direction of the window: “Hey, hey, hey, you two, look outside! Holy crap!”

Nina did not have time to complain about Shirley using crude words again. She stood up without thinking and turned to look toward the window.

Thick shadows of trees swayed outside, filling her sight.

Trees. Trees were everywhere. They were the same tall, lush, unknown giant trees she had seen in the forest of the Nameless One’s Dream. They filled the streets, packed the whole city district, and crowded every inch of her view. The wild flood of green looked like another “Boundless Sea”. Countless crowns of trees rolled together into waves of green, covering the sky between the buildings and even merging with the tallest towers and clocktowers, forming strange, twisted symbiotic pact shapes with them.

It was as if a forest had been directly “laid over” the city-state, as if the dream and the Mortal Realm were merging into one, corrupting each other into a shape beyond understanding.

Vanna, Morris, and Nina came to the floor-to-ceiling window in the living room and stared, dumbfounded, at the scene on the street outside. For a long time, none of them could say a word.

Shirley saw that chaos had already begun on the distant streets.

The residents of the city-state were already waking up in the morning. The shocking changes in the streets clearly went far beyond the old “limits of

perception”. The forest that almost covered the whole city filled people with terror. The plants that had merged with the buildings also destroyed the city’s workings on a physical level. People cried out. Some were trapped inside their own houses. Some buildings were almost completely swallowed, and between the thick, tangled trees, only bits of broken walls and roofs could be seen. The fate of the people who had lived in those buildings was now unknown.

A loud bang came from above a nearby block. A steam pipe had burst. High-temperature, high-pressure gas sprayed from the valves, turning into huge billows of white mist between the crowns of the trees. Somewhere else, a water main ruptured at some node. A huge column of water shot up through the street, forming an astonishing “fountain” between the towering trees.

From far away came the sharp, piercing sirens of Steam Walkers. The city-state’s Guard Corps seemed to be trying to take action, and the academy’s knowledge guardians also seemed to have reacted. Nina heard familiar whistles from the street.

Even though everything was still in chaos, even though everyone had only just jolted awake from the dream, the years of training and the strict, complex emergency procedures still took effect. The forces that kept order charged without hesitation into the dense forest covering the city-state.

But at this moment, they faced a challenge far beyond anything they had imagined.

This was a thick forest, full of living plants.

These were things that had only ever been recorded in old, strange legends and in corrupted books.

The elves who lived in the Deep Sea era had embraced their ancestors' homeland in a way no one had expected, that endless green hell.

In a daze, as wind blew across the city-state, it stirred the leaves in the forest. Countless leaves rose in green waves, and between the waves it was as if whispers came from the forest.

"…You are not elves…"

Brightly colored scraps of paper spun and danced through the dense forest. They drifted lightly past the twisted and changed buildings and past the towering trees rising at different heights. The forest wind carried waves of rustling leaves and faint, whispering murmurs.

Lucretia's figure gathered out of the whirlwind of colored paper and landed on the top of a giant tree near the academy district.

She held a nearby branch with one hand and carefully balanced on the treetop, looking out at the streets that were now covered by forest and twisted by the dream.

Lucretia heard that whisper spreading in the wind. She could even feel the indescribable disappointment and anger mixed into it.

"Rabby." She called softly in her heart.

The Nightmare Rabbit's voice soon sounded in her mind: "Rabby is listening~~"

"How are those cultists doing? Was this their doing?"

"Rabby isn't sure, but they look pretty confused too. The dream collapsed faster than they expected… Even the Saint was alarmed. The people who went Dreamwalking were called in for questioning. Rabby almost got exposed… Good thing Rabby split herself up in advance and hid inside their bodies…"

Lucretia frowned.

“Did you still ‘eat’ them all? I remember reminding you to control your appetite.”

“No, no, only the cultists who went into the Dreamwalking realm. Rabby just left some cotton in their bodies. That was to safely and properly finish the task Mistress gave Rabby,” Rabby hurried to explain. “There are still lots of cultists on the ship. Rabby didn’t touch them…”

Lucretia stayed silent for a few seconds. She felt the tension and fear flowing to her along their soul link. Only then did she speak slowly: “Remember my order clearly. It is for your own good. Don’t forget, that ship and everyone on it are my Father’s prey.”

The Nightmare Rabbit’s voice came at once, this time full of barely hidden fear and nerves: “Yes, Rabby understands. Rabby will absolutely…”

Lucretia cut off the link with the rabbit at once.

Then she steadied herself and, a little awkwardly, called another name in her heart.

She soon heard a reply from far away.

“Lucy, I’m listening.”

“Dad, something has happened in the city-state,” this “Sea Witch” said in a grave tone. “It’s a major event in the Mortal Realm, you should come back quickly.”

Chapter 624:

In fact, when Lucretia sent the message, Duncan was already on his way back to Lightwind Harbor—and he was almost at the city-state.

After confirming that even sending the Vanished far away could not stop the Nameless One’s dream from growing, he had made his choice. While he was acting on the “other side” in Dreamwalking, his body that remained in the Mortal Realm had at once chosen to sail back.

A dark, chaotic sky hung over the sea. Dense black “hair” spread across the surface, giving the whole ocean the look of ink that had soaked deep into the water. Faint, hazy illusions flashed again and again across the distant and nearby waves, while the bizarre sights of the Spirit Realm rose and fell at the edges of his vision.

The Vanished’s sails billowed. The ship swept across the sea of the Spirit Realm like a swift gust of wind. The illusions that kept surfacing on the water fled from the huge vessel. Those that could not dodge in time were caught in the streams of pale green flame that leaked from the ship’s sides and were torn into scraps.

Duncan gripped the wheel and stood at the helm platform on the stern deck. He focused on handling the great ship while listening to the messages Lucretia, Morris, and the others sent from Lightwind Harbor.

Agatha’s phantom stood beside him. In the dim, blurred backdrop of the Spirit Realm, she looked like a Wraith with a form that kept shifting.

Morris’s voice came from the other end of the mental link: “…The forest spreading out from the Nameless One’s dream has covered the whole city. It has already started to damage the city’s systems on a physical level. It is no longer an illusion, but real matter. Dense plants have cut off and sealed many blocks. Large numbers of people are trapped…

“Some buildings have been completely swallowed. Whole houses have been replaced by towering trees, and everyone inside is now missing. We don’t know if they are alive or dead…

“Vanna just went out to observe the streets. She confirmed those plants are real and that they are truly destroying the city. What is even stranger is that these ‘products of the dream’ that have broken into the Mortal Realm are not showing any supernatural traits…

“In addition, we tried to use Psychic Resonance to contact the Storm Cathedral and the Academy Ark. The Church has already discovered the Anomaly in Lightwind Harbor. They have sent out the nearest border fleet…”

Duncan listened in silence to the reports from Lightwind Harbor. His face stayed dark and serious.

The Vanished sped up again. With a speed far beyond that of normal ships, it flew over the sea of the Spirit Realm. From deep within the great ghost ship came a muffled creaking, as if it were answering its captain’s command.

The Nameless One’s dream was growing. But this time, the speed of change clearly went beyond everyone’s expectations. Rather than the natural next step of a vast dream expanding, Duncan felt it looked more like… signs of it slowly entering a runaway state.

“Captain,” Agatha’s voice came from his side, “I have a bad feeling. The way things are going, it makes me think of Frostholm.”

Duncan did not answer. He only frowned a little. Without noticing it, he once again remembered what he had seen in the hold of the Vanished.

The massive spine of an Elder God. The Vanished, which had been rebuilt in Subspace and brought back with Saslokar’s divine authority. And… the puzzle of the ship’s original “keel”.

Slowly, all these clues seemed to line up. They pointed at the mutation now taking place in Lightwind Harbor. They pointed at the Nameless One’s dream that was pushing deeper and deeper into the Mortal Realm.

Duncan suddenly faintly understood something.

Everything was connected. Long, long ago, this ship had already been part of the great whirlpool they were now trapped in.

The beginning of that whirlpool might even be traced back a century, to the day Duncan Abnomar decided to build this giant vessel.

“…We must find Atlantis,” Duncan suddenly said in a low voice.

Agatha did not react for a moment: “Captain?”

“The state of the Nameless One’s dream is tied closely to ‘Atlantis’,” Duncan said. His thoughts were growing clearer as he spoke, and his voice sped up. “From the clues we have, I guess Atlantis is sleeping in the subconscious of all elves. Something must have disturbed this sleeping World Tree and sent her state into a sudden decline. We must find Atlantis.”

“Find her? Where?” Agatha sounded lost. “We have already gone to the border of the Nameless One’s dream, but Atlantis exists there without form in that endless darkness. And according to that silent Goathead, ‘she’ now refuses contact and refuses to wake…”

“But that may not be the only way,” Duncan shook his head. Then he called another name in his heart: “Lucy.”

Lucretia’s voice sounded at once in his mind: “I’m here.”

“Do you still remember when the Vanished was first being built?”

“I… I was very young back then,” Lucretia clearly had not expected Father to bring this up. She sounded a bit flustered. “My memories are very vague. At that time the lords didn’t really let me near the shipyard. Brother may remember more. He was already seven or eight, and he often sneaked off to the place where they were building the ship…”

“Tyrian,” Duncan called without hesitation to another name he had left a mark on. “I have a question for you.”

His mind stayed quiet for two or three seconds. Then a burst of chaotic noise rushed through his thoughts. A crowd of stray ideas had slipped through the barrier of consciousness and leaked out, turning into that noise. After that came Tyrian’s panicked, startled voice: “Father? What happened? Why are you…”

“I heard from Lucy that when the Vanished was being built, you often sneaked over there?”

Even across the distance and the barrier of their minds, Duncan could sense the sudden panic on the other end of the mental link.

Tyrian sounded completely stunned: “I didn’t! Don’t listen to Lucy’s nonsense, she…”

Before he could finish, Lucretia cut in at once: “Brother, just admit it. Lightwind Harbor is in trouble. Dad has a serious question for you.”

Vanna’s voice followed right after: “Mr. Tyrian, this is a very serious matter.”

Tyrian fell silent at once. After a moment, he spoke again. He sounded even more confused than before: “…Why is everyone here?”

“Yes, everyone is here,” Shirley piped up. “Dog is here too.”

“Quiet. This isn’t a place to chat,” Duncan said. Watching this group, who had opened a temporary “channel” in his mind through spirit flame Marks and already started to gossip there, he had no choice but to stop them. “Tyrian, do you remember the time when the Vanished was being built? Do you remember where its ‘keel’ came from?”

Tyrian finally heard the seriousness in Duncan’s tone.

Duncan’s mind went quiet.

After a while, Tyrian’s voice came again: “…Honestly, I don’t remember very clearly either. You wouldn’t tell a child only a few years old any deep shipbuilding knowledge. But I still remember that the ship’s ‘keel’ was something you ‘dragged back’ from a bank of fog near the border after one of your sea expeditions…”

“You dragged it back from fog near the border?”

“Yes. It was one of the ‘spoils’ of that trip. You often found things on your expeditions, and those ‘trophies’ earned you a lot of respect and envy from other explorers. But even among all those spoils, that ‘huge piece of wood’ you dragged back from near the border was the most special one. It was so huge that it even went beyond the towing limit of your ship at the time. You had to call in two smaller ships to assist from the sides, and even then it took almost two months to drag it near Pland…

“You chose Pland not just because our family was living there then, but also because that city-state had the largest shipyard in the world at the time.

“Yes. After that, you announced that you were going to build a ship—the greatest and most astonishing exploration ship in the world—using that

‘timber’ you found in the border fog.

“That ship took a full seven years to build. Even with enough manpower and materials, with the largest and most advanced shipbuilding facilities in the world, and with many shipbuilding experts drawn by your amazing plan and gathering in Pland, it still took seven years before it was finished. And only after it was launched and completed its first voyage, and then went through several more years of adjustments and improvements, did it become that ship the whole world watched—‘the Vanished’.

“My understanding of that ship also slowly formed during that time. Even the story of where that ‘keel’ came from was something I only heard halfway through the construction, from other people. Before that, you rarely told me anything about it.”

Duncan listened in silence to Tyrian’s story in his mind. His expression stayed stern for a long time.

This was indeed the first time he had heard any of this. As the Vanished’s current captain, he had only now learned the story of how the ship was built.

But knowing it now was not too late.

After a brief silence, Duncan asked again: “About that keel… what else do you know?”

Tyrian went silent. It seemed he had fallen into his memories.

Duncan did not know how much time passed. At last Tyrian spoke again: “I remember the artificers who helped build the ship once told me that keel was extremely hard to work. It was not like any known kind of wood. Its toughness was unbelievable. And as a ‘strange thing’ that came from near the ‘border’, it also had some disturbing ‘unnatural’ traits. For example, it

made strange sounds in the middle of the night. The cuts and marks left on its surface would slowly heal.

“Because of those odd traits, the plan to build the Vanished almost stalled at the first step. No one could shape that raw timber into the form of a keel…

“But later, the artificers found something strange.

“Workers with elf blood could cut that ‘timber’ very easily.”

Duncan spoke at once: “Elves?”

“Yes. After they had wasted almost two months working on that great log, an elven artificer discovered this by accident. In elven hands, that keel that had nearly driven everyone mad with how tough it was became as easy to work as soft wood. So later the Pland shipyard transferred all artificers of elven origin to the Vanished project, and they even recruited extra people from nearby city-states…”

Duncan listened carefully. When Tyrian finished, Duncan stayed quiet for a few seconds, then asked: “Besides that, is there anything else?”

“Let me think…” Tyrian said. He thought for a while before speaking again, sounding unsure. “There is one more thing, but I don’t remember it very clearly. It was when the Vanished was almost finished. By then I was allowed to stay at your side and help with some unimportant work. Once you took me to the dry dock. You had been drinking and seemed in very high spirits. You pointed at the Vanished and said to me…

“‘Tyrian, that is actually just a small branch.’

“To this day, I still don’t know what you meant by that.”

—

Chapter 625:

As he listened to Tyrian’s account, Duncan fell into a long silence and deep thought.

The Vanished seemed to fall silent with its captain. The low creaks from deep in the hull slowly faded. A strange, unreal spirit form feeling settled over the ship as it glided soundlessly across the sea, passing through a world that was just as still.

After a long time, Duncan slowly lowered his head and looked toward his feet.

He could not see it, but he could imagine it. Beneath the stacked decks, deeper even than the broken structures at the bottom of the hold, beyond the border of the Mortal Realm, Saslokar’s spine still lay soaked in the dark Subspace. It had taken the place of the Vanished’s original keel—that keel Duncan Abnomar had once called a “small branch”.

That “small branch” had already gone down with the original Vanished a century ago, sinking into the depths of Subspace in that ancient disaster.

“Father…” Tyrian’s uneasy voice sounded in his mind, pulling Duncan from his thoughts. “Do you have any other questions?”

“One last question,” Duncan said. “After the Vanished was finished, some of the artificers who helped build her must still be alive. I mean the elves who worked on the keel…”

“Most of them should still be alive, but it will be hard to find them in a short time,” Tyrian answered. “After the Vanished ‘incident’, everything related to that ship became taboo, including the construction project back then.

“The artificers who once worked on the Vanished switched trades or left for other city-states. Even the elves chose to hide their names and go far away. The design drawings were sealed up. All the files were treated as sealed objects and locked deep inside the Cathedral…

“People say everything connected to the Vanished was struck by the curse. Captain Duncan’s two children were like this, and so were the people who had built the Vanished and knew its secrets. None of them could escape…”

Duncan did not speak. Tyrian also trailed off and fell silent. In the awkward air that followed, Lucretia was the first to break the quiet.

“The rumors were not just rumors. You can’t blame people then for being so nervous,” the “Sea Witch” said slowly. “In fact, the dock that had once been used to build the Vanished burned down on the second day after the Subspace collapse event.

“The fire burned in a way that went against common sense. It burned everything. It turned steel and stone into ash. But it did not burn the blueprints and files related to the Vanished that were stored in the offices.

“Almost half of the people who took part in the construction suffered nightmares, strange illnesses, and hallucinations in the years that followed. Some killed themselves years later. Some vanished at sea. Some went mad. In their last lucid moments, they claimed they had heard the ‘true voice’. After that, they spent the rest of their lives in asylums. Compared to the others who met with misfortune, those who went mad almost seemed lucky.

“The elven artificers who worked on the keel were the least affected. Maybe their race protected them. They did not seem to suffer from the curse, but the fates of the others scared them badly enough. It was only natural that they hid their names and went far away…”

Duncan listened quietly to Lucretia’s memories and description. After a long while, he spoke in a tone that sounded a bit odd: “But the records of the Vanished’s construction are still kept in Pland?”

“Yes, they are still there as sealed objects. You already talked about this with me and Vanna,” Morris cut in. “As far as I know, those things will not be destroyed—and no one dares to destroy them at will. Because Subspace is involved, the act of ‘destroying’ them might itself create a link between the Vanished and the Mortal Realm…”

“I need those things,” Duncan said at once.

Morris paused for a second, then quickly understood: “No problem. I’ll contact some friends in the city-state of Pland. Those items have been high-risk sealed objects for a hundred years, but in the present situation, the authority should be willing to cooperate with your request…”

“Normal contact methods are too slow,” Duncan cut him off. “Vanna.”

Vanna’s voice sounded at once: “Yes, Captain, I’m listening.”

“You can contact the Storm Cathedral in Pland directly, can’t you?” Duncan asked very seriously. “Tell them to gather all materials related to the Vanished’s construction project back then and send them to the Grand Cathedral.”

“…All right,” Vanna said. She hesitated for two or three seconds, as if to show her loyalty to the Storm Goddess, then agreed very readily. “How are you going to collect the documents? Should I send Ai over? I can warn my colleagues there so they don’t panic…”

“No. I’ll go myself.”

For a moment, Vanna did not seem to understand: “You will go yourself?”

…

In the Lower City of Pland, inside a not-very-large antique shop, Duncan put down the newspaper in his hands. He looked once more at the warm, bright sunlight outside the window. A slight smile appeared on his face: “Drinking tea, reading the paper, and basking in the sun in an antique shop every day… It’s time for things to start moving here too.”

“…I understand. I’ll contact the city’s Grand Cathedral right away.”

Vanna’s voice sounded in his mind, then slowly faded.

Duncan carefully folded the newspaper and set it on the rack beside the counter. Then he walked over to the stairs leading to the second floor and took his coat from the hook.

The Vanished was still racing in silence across the Boundless Sea of the Spirit Realm. Lightwind Harbor had sunk into a dream from which it could not wake. In city-states across the world, more and more elves were falling into deep sleep. But in this small antique shop, the old peace and quiet still remained.

This place felt like a harbor of refuge, apart from the whole world.

But just as Duncan put on his coat and prepared to leave, the door of the antique shop was pushed open. The jingle of the bell rang out, breaking the peace of this refuge ahead of time.

Duncan looked up at the door and saw a familiar figure standing in the sunlight.

“Miss Heidi? Good morning,” he said. He recognized the visitor at the door and greeted her politely. “I’m sorry, the shop is closed today. I’m going out

to take care of some business."

"Duncan, Mister… Captain," Heidi took two steps into the shop. She looked at the "shopkeeper" who had just put on his coat and was clearly about to leave. After hesitating for a moment, she said: "I may need your help."

Duncan stopped and looked at her in curiosity: "Hm?"

After the incident with Taran Ael and the elven maiden who had been trapped in a dream, Heidi had already learned the truth about the Vanished. Maybe she had not yet grown used to such drastic changes. For a long time after that, she had hardly ever come to this shop. Duncan had not expected her to suddenly visit today, and even less that she would ask for help as soon as she arrived.

"It's Sleep Sickness," Heidi said. She still sounded hesitant. This was the first time she had come here to seek help after learning who Duncan was, and she clearly felt at a loss. "A large-scale, very sudden case of Sleep Sickness…"

"More elves have fallen asleep?" Duncan frowned. "That is within expectations. The Nameless One's dream went through a violent change at dawn today. Its influence is growing stronger. But don't worry. I'm going out for this very matter."

"It's not only that more elves are falling asleep," Heidi said quickly. "The 'symptoms' this time are also a bit strange. The city's central medical facilities have just taken in a group of patients. I think it is necessary to ask you to look at them… if you have time…"

The more she spoke, the less confident she sounded. Duncan did not know what she had been imagining in the few moments since she entered, but in

the end she suddenly blurted out: “To ask for your help, do we need some kind of sacrificial victims?”

Duncan had been thinking about how long it would take for the Grand Cathedral to prepare the things he wanted. Hearing Heidi’s question, he was taken aback: “…Sacrificial victims?”

Heidi thought for a moment, her face filled with embarrassment: “When I wrote to my father, I didn’t dare ask too many details about you. He only said that life on the Vanished was unbelievable and that your attitude toward mortals was friendly. But he didn’t tell me your rules of action or mention what ritual and what sacrificial victims are needed when we ask you for help…”

“Stop, I understand,” Duncan said at once, cutting her off. He looked at the miss psychiatrist with a very strange expression. After a long moment, he finally said: “I don’t want sacrificial victims, and I don’t need any bloody or creepy sacrificial rituals. The Vanished Fleet is a friendly group whose members help each other and care about the public good of the city-states. Didn’t Morris or Vanna ever tell you that?”

Heidi: “…?”

One look at her face told Duncan everything.

He waved his hand and casually took a bronze figurine from the nearby shelf.

An “antique” from the age of the dark city-states. A royal emblem of the old Isom dynasty. Fresh from the factory last week.

“Original price, eight hundred sola. Discount price, twelve. You can buy it at the original price, and that will count as my fee for helping this once. If you don’t mind, let’s go. The Grand Cathedral won’t be able to get what I

want ready right away anyway. I can go with you first and see how those ‘patients’ are doing.”

…

“You are sure you want to use these things to build the ‘channel’ for Psychic Resonance?” Morris stared, wide-eyed, at Vanna as she worked busily in the kitchen. At last he could not help speaking up.

Vanna paused for a moment and looked up at the old mister beside her: “Is there a problem?”

“…I think this is very lacking in rigor,” Morris said. His face was tight as he did his best to look serious. “When you perform a sacred ritual to connect with the city-state’s Grand Cathedral, you should at least prepare some proper spell materials…”

Vanna stayed silent for a moment, then lowered her head to look at what she had found in this “witch manor”.

“Holy fire, holy oil, holy spices, and devout benediction. All four elements are here.”

Morris’s eyes flew wide open: “It doesn’t work just because you put the word ‘holy’ in front! You can’t fry some scallions in the kitchen and expect the Goddess to send down her power!”

Vanna: “…”

Chapter 626: Call

To be fair, Vanna had to admit that Morris, the old gentleman, was right.

Fire, Holy Oil, and incense were the three key elements of a sacred ritual. In special situations, you could improvise, but replacing all of them with whatever you could find in a kitchen was still a bit hard to justify.

But she still decided to try.

After all, first, she had already tried it more than once back when she was on the Vanished. Second, she really could not find any better materials in this witch's mansion.

"I really shouldn't have expected a witch's home to have anything like Holy Oil," Vanna sighed and said to Morris helplessly. "I've been careless about my everyday preparations."

Morris muttered under his breath: "I keep feeling that ever since you managed to hold a ritual on the ship with cheap materials, you stopped thinking about preparing proper ritual materials at all…"

Vanna shrugged and pointed toward the window: "Then maybe you could find a way to buy some from the street?"

Morris lifted his head and glanced at the street outside, where tree shadows swayed. Thinking about how chaotic Lightwind Harbor was right now, he decided it was better not to answer.

Shirley, who had rushed over to watch the show, was holding Dog and staring at Vanna's work with interest. She suddenly said: "Why not add

some ginger and garlic too?”

Vanna froze, confused: “Why?”

Shirley said: “When your ritual is over, we can ask Lunie to stir-fry two dishes with it—I’m hungry.”

“…Don’t make fun of it so casually!” Vanna finally felt her expression slipping. She glared at Shirley, trying hard to look stern and serious. “This is a solemn ritual. I’m only improvising because of the situation…”

Shirley fell silent, just pulled Dog and quietly edged closer to the door.

Vanna stared, baffled: “…Why are you backing so far away?”

“I don’t really understand you clerics and all this flashy stuff,” Shirley waved a hand. “But my gut says I’d better stand farther away. When the lightning strikes you later, I don’t want your blood splashing on me.”

Vanna: “…”

The Inquisitor tried hard to calm herself and decided to ignore the figures watching at the door. She took a slow breath and focused on the ritual to build a psychic channel.

The flames rose, and the fat began to boil.

No matter what, fire was still fire. At any time, the lighting of a flame stood for the first step of a civilization. It was a sign, a sign mortals showed to the deities, and it had only one meaning—“I am here.”

Long ago, ever since she had just graduated and left the seminary, Vanna had always thought this way—the form of the fire did not matter. The act of lighting it was the meaning.

As one of the most outstanding clerics of the younger generation in the Deep Sea Church, this had been the only thought Vanna had, in all those

years, that could be called “not quite in line with doctrine”—and even that was only true for those past years.

Now she had far too many thoughts and actions that strayed from doctrine.

The soft sound of waves echoed in the ears of this Inquisitor who was growing more and more “rebellious.”

She sensed a gaze. A gentle divine gaze fell on her and then turned away. The “channel” opened before her eyes, and from the far end of that channel came the voice of Bishop Valentine.

“Vanna?” The old bishop sounded a bit surprised. “I did not expect to suddenly hear your call… Wait, what is that smell?”

“That is not important, Archbishop.” Vanna steadied herself and spoke in a serious tone. “I have to tell you something, and you must not panic…”

“What is it?”

“The captain will come to the Great Storm Cathedral to see you soon. He wants the construction records of the Vanished—all of them.”

…

Duncan frowned slightly as he stood in the ward with Heidi, looking at the young elf lying on the hospital bed.

“This patient was only admitted this morning. There are dozens more like him now—several elf communities have already started to panic, because no one knows if the next to collapse or vanish will be themselves,” Heidi said softly. “The incident has already reached supernatural corruption level. The cathedral has sent Guardian units to take over those communities, but aside from constantly sending elves with strange symptoms here, they have no good way to deal with it.”

Duncan nodded with a grave expression, then stepped forward and bent down to study the condition of the young elf on the bed.

The elf's whole body had a hazy, unreal look, like a phantom that could fade away at any moment, barely clinging to a humanoid outline on the bed.

This clearly went beyond the earlier cases of Sleep Sickness and was no longer a "symptom" that normal medicine could handle.

"He is disappearing, leaving our Mortal Realm dimension in a way that is hard to understand. This is no longer something a psychiatrist can handle. I used some methods from the supernatural field, but I can only barely keep their minds on this side and slow the process of 'disappearance,'" Heidi said from behind Duncan. "On one patient whose symptoms were lighter, I tried Thought Reading, but I found that their thoughts were being slowly drawn away by something… much larger. It is like a vortex dragging these elves out of the Mortal Realm, from mind to body."

Duncan listened to her description with a deep frown. After a long moment, he spoke as if to himself: "Atlantis is taking them away."

Heidi was stunned: "Atlantis?"

"That is the 'vortex' you sensed. I suggest you stop trying things in that direction," Duncan said, face very serious. "Because it is very likely that this vortex will treat you as an elf too."

Heidi's face changed at once.

Duncan, meanwhile, shifted part of his attention to watch what was happening far away—

The Vanished was already drawing close to the sea near Lightwind Harbor and was preparing to surface from the Spirit Realm.

Vanna had just sent word. She had successfully contacted the Great Storm Cathedral in Pland. Bishop Valentine would prepare everything as quickly as possible and wait for the “captain” to visit.

Inside Lightwind Harbor, things were still in chaos. The thick forest was like a boundless green hell to the residents of the city-state. Even the well-trained Guard Corps and the Guardian troops could hardly deal with something so far beyond imagination—Lucretia was already moving through the city-state, trying to give as much help as she could.

And in the distant northern city-state of Frostholm, Sleep Sickness was spreading just like it was here in Pland.

It was easy to imagine that the spread of Sleep Sickness was not limited to Pland and Frostholm. As the situation in Lightwind Harbor grew worse, it was likely that elves all over the world were facing the same terrible crisis—Atlantis was devouring them.

But why was it like this? Why had the World Tree, rooted in the very memory of the elves as a race, suddenly undergone such an extreme change?

Just then, a faint sound from the bed suddenly broke Duncan’s thoughts.

The elf lying on the bed, who had been in a deep sleep and was slowly turning transparent, suddenly moved. His body twitched slightly, and a low, muffled groan came from his throat.

He seemed as if he were about to wake up.

Heidi noticed at once. She rushed to the bed, as if wanting to check whether this elf was really regaining consciousness. But at that moment, the same thing suddenly happened on the other beds in the ward.

The elves in deep sleep began to twitch one after another, the same muffled groans rising from their throats!

The eerie scene made Heidi’s scalp prickle. She straightened up sharply and looked toward Duncan on instinct. At that very moment, all the muffled groans in the elves’ throats stopped at the same time.

The next second, the sleeping elves opened their mouths at once, as if a single mind had finally linked to all these bodies in the Mortal Realm at the same time. They spoke in clear voices—

“I am Ted Riel. I am now in the deepest part of the Nameless One’s dream.

“I am sending this message to the Mortal Realm through every path I can find. Whoever hears it, please spread it to as many people as possible—

“Atlantis has gone mad.

“She is trying to devour all elves and use that to enter the Mortal Realm and take root and grow again.

“She is not our protector. What she protects is not us.

“We are fighting against Atlantis’s main consciousness and trying our best to slow her spread toward the Mortal Realm—but we are losing.

“We need help. Do everything possible to keep the elves in the Mortal Realm from being devoured by Atlantis, to stop them from vanishing or dying in their sleep. This can slow Atlantis’s awakening. I repeat, we need help…”

The voices in the ward cut off at once.

All the elven patients sank back into “sleep,” as if what had just happened were only an illusion—Ted Riel’s link to the Mortal Realm had been cut off.

“Ted Riel…” Heidi stared for a few seconds before she reacted. “The Truth Keeper from Lightwind Harbor?!”

Panic and horror appeared in her eyes. The short few seconds just now had made her realize how terrible and serious the situation was.

She looked at Duncan, wanting to seek help from this “captain.”

Duncan’s brow knit tight. The sudden change of events and the message from Ted Riel were beyond what he had expected, but after a brief, fast chain of thoughts, he vaguely caught some lines of direction from those words.

“Looks like I have to go,” he turned his head and said to Miss Psychiatrist, his face serious. “Someone has to solve this from the root.”

Heidi spoke without thinking: “Then what about things here…”

“Keep doing what you are doing. Slow down how fast these elves are being ‘devoured,’” Duncan said quickly. “Hold their spirits in the Mortal Realm for as long as you can—leave the rest to us.”

Chapter 627: The “Sample” Preserved Till Today

The terrible “sleep” and disappearance were spreading across the whole world. From the distant Northern Seas to the southern oceans, from the mist-filled eastern borders to the western archipelago, almost every city-state had elves who suddenly fell into slumber, and strange, unexplainable “disappearances.”

And the message Ted Riel sent from the depths of the Nameless One’s dream was also being spread to the whole world through the mouths of those sleeping elves.

Cathedrals rang their bells one after another. Telegraphs and psychic communication began to carry news between city-states. Governors and archbishops shared updates in real time, and the joint monitoring and defense system that the Four Gods Church had only recently created now started up in haste.

People had thought this system would be used to watch the Deep Sea beneath the city-states. No one expected its first real use to be because of a dream that had entered a runaway state.

A whirlwind made of fluttering, colored paper scraps spun through layers of vines, leaves, and rooftops, drilling straight into the governor’s office in the city hall.

Governor Sara Mell, who had been talking with several city hall officials, raised her head at once and looked at the “sea witch” stepping out from the

colored paper.

“I suddenly remembered I should come check on city hall,” Lucretia walked over to the large oval desk. “You look very busy.”

“Up to my neck in trouble, Lady,” Sara Mell waved to the city hall officials beside her, dismissing them for now. “I heard you just helped the constable units that were trapped in trouble—thank you very much for your help.”

“How are things now?”

“The city is in chaos. Sixteen districts have completely lost contact. Thick vegetation has blocked every road. A large number of residents are missing. The Security Corps and the Guardians can hardly get into those areas. The steam hubs have shut down. For safety, we also turned off gas for the whole city—thank the gods that at least can still be shut off, but no one knows what we are supposed to do tonight,” Sara Mell said in one breath. “As for outside the city… I imagine you already know what is happening elsewhere. Countless reports are coming in from every channel, but I really do not have any extra energy to pay attention to other city-states now.”

“What about the message from Ted Riel? Do you know about that?”

“Yes, I know,” Sara Mell nodded. “First, two hours ago, we got word from the team that Taran Ael was part of. They said that after the team left the dream, the Truth Keeper did not return to the Mortal Realm. Half an hour ago, I received the latest report. His Excellency the Truth Keeper is trapped in the deepest part of the Nameless One’s dream…”

She stopped, a hard-to-describe, complex look on her face. It seemed she wanted to let out a long sigh, but in the end only the corner of her mouth twitched. “Elves have always been proud of our long, complete heritage. We believe that those ancient tales and myths were once real history,

symbols of our old civilization—and now our tales and myths have come to kill us."

Lucretia silently watched the respected governor. After a moment, she finally spoke slowly: "But until last night, the information we had still said that Atlantis wanted to shelter the elves in the Sanctuary World. Even now, I have reason to believe that this 'protection' is still working—only… in a very dangerous way."

Sara Mell's face twitched. "…Yes. Because Atlantis has gone mad."

"I want to see Taran Ael and the other knowledge guards who went into the Nameless One's dream with him," Lucretia said. "I did not find them at the city-state university."

"They are in a quarantine facility under observation and questioning. I will tell you where it is…"

…

The solemn Great Storm Cathedral stood quietly on the highest ground in Pland. The square in front of the Great Cathedral was as lively as ever—on every open day, many citizens gathered here: some entered the cathedral to worship, some came to the nearby facilities to receive divine blessings and treatment, and some were simply here to visit.

Duncan wore a plain brown coat and black trousers. He followed the group of visitors entering the cathedral through the grand archway, then walked deeper inside along the route Vanna had described in his mind.

He passed through the main hall and the prayer aisle open to visitors, then through a side corridor next to the preaching area, and kept going along a route that even many of the cathedral's own staff did not know well.

In his mind, the voice of the Inquisitor sounded: "…Go through that small black door up ahead. After you enter, turn right. After about twenty meters

there is a fork, and the path on the left leads to the inner courtyard…

"…This route is the quietest. If you keep going to the end, you will see the side door of the inner chapel. I have already spoken with Bishop Valentine and asked him to wait for you in the chapel. Everything along the way has been arranged. No one will stop you, and the guards on the way do not know who you are… Yes, only Bishop Valentine knows the truth…

"…If you want to come to the Great Cathedral again in the future, you can also use this route. By the way, the room where I used to rest in the Great Cathedral is right next to the chapel. You could also go there… though I know you will not need it…"

Listening to the Inquisitor's voice in his mind, Duncan lifted his gaze.

The inner chapel was ahead. This place was not open to the public and was only for the high-ranking priests of the Deep Sea Church. A plain black wooden door stood quietly at the end of the path, with two fully armed church guards standing tall on either side, like two grim statues.

Duncan walked toward the door.

The guards at the door did not even move their eyes. It was as if they could not see Duncan at all. They kept their serious, forward-facing stares.

This was clearly the result of arrangements made in advance. Duncan could almost imagine what orders the guards along this path had received—

Today, a special guest would visit the Great Cathedral.

Do not listen. Do not look. Do not ask. Do not think.

He gave them a polite smile, then walked past the two guards and gently pushed open the black door covered with sacred sigils.

A faint sound of waves rose and faded in his ears, and a damp, cold breath seemed to appear for a moment and then quickly vanish. Duncan felt as if

he had stepped through an invisible barrier, and then he entered a wide, brightly lit room.

Valentine, the highest bishop of the city-state of Pland, was standing in the center of the room.

The thin-haired old man wore a black priest's robe patterned with gold. He stood with his back to the door, facing a statue of the Storm Goddess that filled the room with a mysterious, holy air, and seemed to be in devout benediction. Only when he heard the door open did he turn and look at the special guest standing at the entrance.

It was easy to see that the old man was a little nervous, even though he was trying hard to control it.

"Hello, Bishop Valentine. We meet again," Duncan said with a slight smile as he walked toward him. "But for you, this should be the first time seeing me in this 'form.'"

Valentine examined the "Duncan" who had entered the room with curiosity.

What he saw was only an ordinary middle-aged man in a simple old coat, neither tall nor strong, the kind you could see anywhere in the city-state.

But after only a second, the sharp warning from his reason urged him to shift his gaze away and stop staring at that shell which only looked like a human body.

"I know. This is the avatar form you use when you move through the city-state. I heard Vanna mention it," Valentine lowered his eyes a little. "She also told me about the situation. Everything you asked for is ready."

The old bishop raised his hand and pointed to a large wooden chest next to the statue.

There lay the original records from when the Vanished had been built a century ago, and… one very important “sample.”

Several bright candle stands had been set up around the chest. Now and then, faint illusions rose in the candle flames, showing that they had been given divine blessings. On either side of the chest, Duncan could see stone slabs, iron chains, and other sealing items, clearly also part of the safety measures.

It seemed that even after this chest of “shipbuilding records” had been taken out of the sealed vault and placed here in the chapel watched directly by the Goddess, it was still treated with extreme care. Bishop Valentine had come here ahead of time to keep watch, most likely also to guard against anything inside the chest entering a runaway state.

“…Is it really that dangerous?” Duncan walked toward the chest, then could not help turning his head to ask: “Do these sealing measures actually do anything?”

“In fact, no,” Valentine answered quite bluntly. “Because nothing in this chest has ever actually ‘acted up.’”

Duncan froze for a moment. “Then all this is…”

“For peace of mind,” Valentine said frankly. “Nothing in the chest has acted up, but everyone knows it must have some link, in terms of supernatural, with the Vanished. So we simply used every sealing method we could think of—the version you see here is already simplified. In the sealed vault where this chest was originally stored, there were far more ‘safety measures’ than this.”

Duncan had nothing to say to that.

After a moment, he shook his head, ignored the sudden awkwardness in the air, and stepped forward to open the chest.

The chest was not locked—the lock had already been removed when it was brought here.

“The Vanished’s original design blueprints, technical parameters, and engineering logs… In fact, the full set of records was much larger, but the less important parts were all burned to ash in the shipyard fire back then. Only these were left and sealed in this chest…”

Valentine’s voice came from beside him. The old bishop had walked to Duncan’s side and now looked down into the chest as he spoke in a low voice.

“Of course, I guess what you really want is not just these plans, but… that thing in the middle of the chest.

“The keel sample kept according to the shipbuilding customs of a century ago.”

Duncan’s gaze rested quietly on the gray-black block of wood lying in the middle of a piece of black silk.

It was the “sample” cut from the original keel of the Vanished.

Chapter 628: The curse of the Lost Ones

A century ago, in the age of sailing warships, the shipbuilding artificers of every city-state followed one rule when they built a ship – while they worked the keel, they had to cut a block of wood from the original timber.

They would treat this block the same way they treated the keel itself: charring it, soaking it in chemicals, oiling it, then placing it on the slipway beside the unfinished ship. When the ship was finally completed, this keel timber block would be left behind in the shipyard, kept on land forever.

Usually, shipowners would pay an extra fee so the priests of the city could perform regular divine blessing rituals over the block. Sometimes they would even send it to the Cathedral and ask the Church to store and watch over it there.

At first, keeping this keel sample was part of quality control. Shipowners used it to test whether the keel's material and preliminary treatment met the technical standards of a ship. Later, it turned into a symbol of praying for safety.

People believed that a ship had a soul, and that the keel left on land would bring good luck to the vessel at sea. It was like a lighthouse, letting lost ships find the route back to shore. The blessings that clerics laid upon the keel timber block could also fall upon the ship on its voyage. And if disaster truly struck, that keel left on shore would become a little ferryboat in the world of the dead, carrying the sailors' souls back home.

In the past, once a ship was confirmed lost, the priests of the God of Death would even take out the keel timber block left on land and hold a “funeral” for it. The families of the lost crew members would see that block off as if it were the body of their loved ones, and watch as it was sent into the furnace.

Agatha had once, out of curiosity, described in great detail to Duncan what those death priests’ farewell ceremonies for a keel sample had been like a hundred years ago.

In fact, this custom still survived in a weakened form even now. With the progress of the age, people no longer always chose to keep a ship’s keel sample. Many times, younger captains preferred to keep a section of pipe cut off during the installation of the steam core, storing it either in the shipyard or at the Cathedral.

Duncan quietly let his gaze rest on the block of wood inside the chest.

The Vanished was a ship built a hundred years ago. No matter how special it was now, back when it lay in the shipyard, it had been built under the same rules and habits as any ordinary vessel.

The artificers of that time had kept its keel sample.

Not the Elder Gods spine it carried now, but its original keel – that “little twig” Duncan Abnomar had found in the mist near the border.

Duncan reached out and carefully picked up the plain-looking piece of wood.

He suddenly widened his eyes a little: “No weight?!”

The “weight” that came from the keel sample shocked him. It was too light… so light that the word “light” was no longer enough. Just as he had blurted out, it felt like it had no weight at all, lighter than a speck of dust in his hand.

Yet Duncan clearly saw the deep dent pressed into the black silk lining inside the chest where the block had rested. That mark had been made by the wood's weight.

"Yes, no weight – but only when someone holds it," Bishop Valentine's voice came from beside him. "When we put it on the scale, its weight is 0.7 kilograms. When a living person holds it, its weight is 0 milligrams. But it was not like this at first. According to the records, when it was just cut from the keel timber, it was no different from ordinary wood – I mean in terms of weight."

Duncan frowned. He already had an answer in his heart, but he still could not help asking: "When did the change happen?"

"On the day the Vanished fell into Subspace," Valentine answered. "Many things happened that day. Most of them were only investigated and confirmed after people slowly recovered from the chaos. Besides the keel sample losing its weight in the hands of the living, we also found that, other than this sample, every other piece of wood cut from the Vanished's keel timber had vanished."

The old bishop paused, then explained further: "The original timber you brought to Pland back then was enormous. Even after it was worked into a keel, the leftover cuts were still enough for many other uses. The records say that part of the leftovers was made into various fittings on the Vanished. The rest you left in the shipyard's warehouse.

"Some years later, you took part of that stock again to make the figureheads and steering wheels of the Sea Mist and the Radiant Star. The final leftovers were too poor to use and stayed in the warehouse, until… the day of the accident."

As he spoke, the old man stepped forward and pointed at the large chest in front of Duncan.

“The related records about that are also inside.”

“The Sea Mist and the Radiant Star were built in Pland too? And they used the Vanished’s leftover keel wood? Are their construction records still around?”

“Sadly, the records for those two ships were turned to ash in the great fire at the shipyard that year, together with their keel samples,” Valentine shook his head. “People say that was when the two ships first fell under the curse. The storm the Vanished stirred up in Subspace destroyed the ‘anchors’ those two ships had left on land, and from that moment on, they slowly turned into what they are today.”

At this point, the old bishop suddenly seemed to realize that his words might be a bit off. He hurriedly coughed twice: “Ahem, I hope you don’t mind. These are all just…”

“It’s fine. You’re only stating things that really happened – things I asked you about,” Duncan said, shaking his head. “And my relationship with the children is very good now. That is all in the past.”

As Duncan spoke, he lowered his eyes again to the weightless keel sample in his hand.

Many things finally became clear today.

Everything that had wound around and around, that had once seemed like a chaotic tangle, was in fact just a single loop of thread. And now, the end of that thread had finally fallen into his hand.

“If you still want to know more about what happened back then, I can try to find the elven artificers who worked on the Vanished,” Valentine said carefully, watching Duncan’s expression. “But that may not be easy. After all… things are not going well among the elves right now.”

“I know. I came here to solve that,” Duncan let out a light breath and set his thoughts aside for the moment. He nodded to Valentine. “This is enough. I have what I wanted. I will be taking this chest with me.”

“Of course,” Valentine nodded at once. “In fact… it is better if you take it.”

Duncan naturally knew why Valentine said that. He only smiled, then carefully put the block of wood back into the chest and closed the lid.

He was just about to summon Ai to send the chest back to the Vanished when he noticed a hesitant look on Valentine’s face.

“Is there something else?”

“Uh…” Valentine tensed up so visibly that the change could be seen with the naked eye. He hesitated for several seconds before he finally spoke: “Actually, I have been thinking about one question since just now, but I was afraid you might find it offensive…”

“Say it.”

“…Vanna hasn’t caused any trouble on your ship, has she?”

“Trouble? Why would you say that?” Duncan felt confused. “She is very mature and steady. She is easy to have on board. How could she cause trouble?”

Valentine stared at him for a moment before he finally squeezed out a line: “She didn’t break anything? She is blunt, hard to get along with, very strong, and she had few friends in the city…”

Duncan did not answer right away. He first thought of Nina, who was one surprise and explosion after another. Then he thought of Shirley, who could turn the whole ship upside down over a few test papers, and of Alice, who would stew herself into a soup every now and then. He also thought of that

whole bunch of pots, pans, mops, buckets, and even gunpowder cannons on the ship that clanged, chattered, and made a racket day and night…

“She is doing very well,” Duncan said very seriously to the old bishop. “She is already one of the quiet ones on the ship. She only makes a bit of noise when she runs and trains on the deck in the morning…”

Valentine: “…?”

The old bishop still could not imagine what Vanna’s life on the Vanished actually looked like.

But Duncan did not plan to explain further. He quickly summoned Ai, had her teleport the large wooden chest straight to the faraway Vanished, then said goodbye to the old bishop and strode out of the Grand Cathedral.

Inside the brightly lit inner chapel, Valentine stood dazed in front of the holy statue of the storm Goddess. In a blur, he suddenly felt that everything that had happened this morning was unreal.

This holy place had really received a shadow from Subspace – and now that shadow had calmly left.

It felt like a dream.

“…Vanna.”

“I’m here.” The psychic channel was still open, and Vanna’s voice sounded in Valentine’s ear. “Has the captain left?”

“…He just left,” Valentine said.

Perhaps the hesitation and strange mood in the old bishop’s voice was too obvious, because Vanna quickly sensed something was off: “What’s wrong? Did something go badly?”

“That’s not it. I just feel a bit strange…” Valentine said slowly. “Tell me… does this count as the Grand Cathedral being invaded by Subspace?”

Vanna clearly had not expected the old bishop to say something like that. She fell silent for several seconds before she answered, a little unsure: “I… don’t know either.”

Valentine turned his head and glanced at the statue of Gamona standing quietly in the candlelight. “The Goddess does not seem displeased.”

“I don’t think the Goddess would be,” Vanna said with some certainty. “After all, the captain only came over for a visit. If that really counts as an invasion, then the death Grand Cathedral in Frostholm gets invaded by Subspace every Friday… and nothing has happened over there.”

Valentine: “…?”

Chapter 629: Countless Threads

“I don’t think you should call my trip every Friday to the Frostholm Grand Cathedral to collect my cemetery guard wages a ‘Subspace invasion’. That is not very precise…”

On the Vanished, which was sailing through the shallow layers of the Spirit Realm, Duncan checked the large wooden chest that Ai had just teleported from Pland while he spoke to Vanna in his heart.

“It is exactly because I want to be precise that I call it that,” Vanna replied. Her tone was so serious that Duncan could not tell whether the inquisitor was joking. She paused, then sounded even more earnest. “And honestly, I have never understood why you insist on personally using your avatar form to collect that ‘wage’. You know, that ‘Agatha’ in Frostholm is willing to assign a special team of guards for you. Mr. Tyrian has also wanted to arrange a better place for your avatar form over there. But you still insist on warding those graveyards yourself…”

Duncan stopped what he was doing. In a brief silence, he thought of that cold northern city-state – that place where it was always snowing. He remembered the winter graveyard, the quiet streets, a young lady named Annie, and the old caretaker.

“…I like that place,” Duncan said slowly in his heart. “Doing some things an ordinary person would do, in a place I like – that is my hobby.”

Vanna fell quiet for a moment, as if his words had touched her and sent her into thought. Light, quick footsteps came from not far away. Duncan looked

up and saw Alice happily walking over from the other end of the deck – she was always that cheerful.

“Captain! Are we almost at Lightwind Harbor? I saw the ship start to ‘rise’…”

The doll suddenly noticed the large chest sitting on the deck.

“What is this?” she asked in surprise as she hurried over, circling the chest and peeking at the things inside. “Is it for me to sleep in… no, that doesn’t look right. What are these?”

“These are very important things, the construction records from when the Vanished was first built,” Duncan said casually, reaching in to pick up the block of wood. “But this is the most important part.”

Alice leaned closer, curious: “What is it?”

Duncan stayed silent for a long time. Only when he saw Alice’s curious and puzzled gaze did he finally speak in a low voice: “Maybe… an ‘interface’.”

He lifted his head and looked out at the distant sea.

The chaos and darkness in the sky were slowly fading. The black “hairs” in the sea were thinning at a speed the naked eye could see. The hazy, ghostly shapes on the water first turned into thin mist, then quickly paled and melted away in the strengthening sunlight. The Vanished was slowing down. Under Goathead’s control, it was rising from the Spirit Realm back toward the Mortal Realm.

“The Vanished has already drawn near Lightwind Harbor. How is the situation in the city now?”

Morris’s voice answered at once: “It is still chaotic, but some guards and constables have made it into the districts. The emergency officials are

organizing the residents to save themselves. For now, it doesn't look like things will get worse – but no one can guarantee how tonight will be."

Duncan answered with a quiet "mm", then turned his attention back to the sea.

The Vanished completed its rise. Bright sunlight from the Mortal Realm shone on the deck and masts. Beyond the rail, the sea swelled gently in the breeze, whitecaps flashing with scattered light.

As far as the eye could see, there was nothing.

Duncan blinked. Something felt wrong.

Alice also blinked. Even this solid-headed doll felt something was wrong.

A hazy shadow squirmed up from the deck and slowly stood, staring into the distance. After quite a while, Agatha finally broke the silence on the deck: "Where is Lightwind Harbor?!"

Where was Lightwind Harbor?! Where had that huge Lightwind Harbor gone?!

Duncan stared out at the distance for a long time, then turned his head to look in other directions. He swept his gaze around the sea and finally found something familiar.

A huge, irregular luminous geometric body was floating quietly on the distant water.

It was the fallen relic that had been "anchored" near Lightwind Harbor. But aside from that enormous luminous geometric body, there was nothing on the nearby sea.

Duncan called out at once through the mental link: "First Mate, confirm our position."

Goathead answered immediately: “Aye, captain, I have already noticed it… There’s nothing wrong with the Vanished’s position. The enchanted sea chart shows we are right next to Lightwind Harbor, and that ‘luminous geometric body’ can be used as a reference point… but Lightwind Harbor is gone.”

A sea breeze blew across the deck. The bright southern sunlight reflecting off the water was almost too dazzling to look at.

Far away, a mark formed from the fire of spirit form burned somewhere no eyes could see. Duncan heard Nina’s voice rise from the depths of his mind: “Uncle Duncan, have you arrived?”

“I have,” Duncan took a slow breath, thinking of how to explain the situation. “But Lightwind Harbor is gone.”

Nina: “…Huh?”

Some time later.

The Vanished reached the waters where the huge luminous geometric body floated, and within its range they finally found a trace that proved Lightwind Harbor had once existed.

Duncan found the research station built to study the “stone sphere” at the center of the geometric body. It still remained in the Mortal Realm, but the station itself was completely empty.

Judging from the traces left behind, the scholars stationed there had disappeared at least before dawn. The stoves for cooking breakfast showed no signs of use. Several divine blessing oil lamps that needed to be lit only during the night were still burning, their fuel almost exhausted. This meant that after sunrise, no one had been there to put them out.

After a round of investigation, the Vanished left the luminous core of the geometric body and returned to the patch of sea where Lightwind Harbor

should have been, wandering slowly back and forth over the spot.

“The research facilities around the stone sphere are still there. Maybe the ‘sunlight’ that luminous geometric body gives off weakened the power of the Nameless One’s dream. But the staff inside are all gone… It seems that ‘sunlight’ could not completely block Atlantis’s strength.”

In the captain’s cabin of the Vanished, Duncan was analyzing the situation. Not far from him, inside the oval scrying mirror, Agatha also wore a solemn, thoughtful expression.

“This looks very similar to the disappearances in Lightwind Harbor whenever the Nameless One’s dream broke out,” Agatha said as she thought aloud. “But this time, the power of the dream has grown to an unbelievable level. Even an entire city-state with material form has vanished.”

Alice stood beside Duncan. The doll, who usually had such a wide and careless heart, finally looked nervous, even a little afraid. She grabbed Duncan’s arm without thinking and spoke in a hesitant voice: “Then… then everyone who stayed in the city…”

“They are all safe for now. I can still contact them,” Duncan comforted the doll. “Going by the pattern the Nameless One’s dream showed before, as long as the dream disperses, anything that vanished because of it should return to normal.”

Hearing the captain’s words, Alice still felt that something was wrong, but she relaxed a little.

But Duncan knew he had not said everything.

The biggest question now was whether this time the Nameless One’s dream would fade away like before – and whether this might be Atlantis’s “final dream”.

The message Ted Riel had sent from the depths of the Nameless One's dream was very bad.

Atlantis had gone mad. She had changed from an ancient obsession half-asleep in a muddled daze into a powerful being with clear ability to act but no control. That being's goal was clear: to take root and grow once more in the Mortal Realm.

Now that she was awake and insane, would Atlantis still, like in the previous times, unconsciously let the Nameless One's dream come to a quiet end? Or… was the current "disappearance" of Lightwind Harbor the first step for her to enter the Mortal Realm?

Time was running out.

Duncan thought quickly. He placed the keel sample he had found in Pland on the chart table before him, and at the same time considered how to use this piece of wood to establish contact with Atlantis, how to truly reach the deepest part of the Nameless One's dream, and how to discover what truth was hidden in the Veil at the core of that dream.

The Sea Mist and the Radiant Star had already mutated under the curse. The original keel of the Vanished had disappeared into Subspace. The leftover "twig" timbers from back then had been burned to ash in the shipyard fire. The piece before him was probably the last remaining "Atlantis wood" in the world. There was likely only one chance.

Just as some ideas began to form in Duncan's mind, Alice suddenly cried out beside him: "Threads!"

Duncan turned in surprise: "Threads? You see threads in here?"

"Threads… threads everywhere!" Alice's eyes were wide. She waved her hands in the air as she spoke quickly. "They just floated out. They're all over the air… rising up from under the deck!"

“Under the deck?” Duncan froze for a second, then reacted at once. He grabbed Alice’s arm and pulled the doll toward the door. “Come with me!”

Alice did not understand at first. She ran after the captain, shouting as she went: “Hey… hey? Captain, where are you taking me? Slow down, slow down, let me hold my head…”

Alice’s cries cut off the moment she stepped out of the captain’s cabin.

She stood on the deck, staring wide-eyed at the endless sea outside.

The Sun was slowly sinking. In the magnificent glow spreading across the sky, she saw something she had never seen before: countless hair-fine threads rising and drifting up from the whole stretch of sea.

Those threads were not floating up from “under the deck” of the Vanished.

They were floating up from the sea where Lightwind Harbor had once been.

Chapter 630: Academy Ark

There were countless threads there, rising from the surface of the sea like masses of growing hair. They drifted upward into the air as if weightless—and more and more of them were still appearing.

Alice stared wide-eyed at the scene, both confused and shocked. Then a ghostly green flame flashed across her eyes. The same flame flickered in Duncan's eyes, and the "threads" that only the doll could see appeared in his sight as well.

"Are these… the people of Lightwind Harbor?" Alice muttered after a long pause, finally breaking the silence. "Their bodies are gone, but all the threads are still here?"

Duncan did not answer. He only watched the dense, floating threads with a serious face. He could not count them with a single glance, but he could faintly feel that there were too many of them. Even if he assumed each person had five threads extending from them, the number here far exceeded the elven population of Lightwind Harbor. It was as if… all the soul-threads of the elves in the world had gathered here.

Their sheer number made the continuous mass of threads look hazy. They drifted in the wind without a fixed shape, hanging over the sea above Lightwind Harbor like a mist that refused to disperse. It even carried a kind of dreamlike… beauty.

And a horrifying strangeness.

By now, Alice had already recovered from her initial fright. She watched the clumps of threads over the sea with curiosity, looking like a cat that had suddenly seen a pile of yarn balls—unable to hold back, yet still hesitant. She remembered what the captain usually told her, so she carefully pulled her hands back, trying hard not to touch any of the nearby threads. But her eyes darted everywhere, wanting to grab them yet not daring to.

This of course did not escape Duncan's eyes.

"Captain, I'll just touch one, just a little. I won't grab anything… I just want to check their 'state'…" Alice spoke quickly and carefully the moment she noticed Duncan looking her way. She raised her hand and pinched her fingers together, showing how small her "little touch" would be.

Duncan nodded silently and watched the doll's hands very closely.

He certainly trusted Alice—but he did not trust Alice to be reliable.

Once the doll had permission, she instantly looked happy. She then carefully reached out and touched the nearest invisible thread.

A second later, she let out a low cry and quickly let go.

Duncan asked at once: "What's wrong?"

"…Weird thing." Alice stared at the thread in a bit of a daze and muttered in puzzlement.

Duncan frowned when he heard that: "Weird thing?"

"I don't know what it is, but it's not like any of the 'threads' I touched before," Alice said hesitantly, as if trying hard to turn what she felt into words. "I felt something… very, very huge, hiding at the other end of the thread. But that thing was blurry, and it seemed to be changing all the time…"

As she spoke, she lifted her hand and pointed toward the deepest part of that veil-like mass of threads.

“It feels like it’s hiding in there, but I still can’t see it.”

Duncan frowned and looked at that hazy “white mist.” He did not see the “weird thing” Alice described, but he knew what it was.

Atlantis had already begun to condense a mental entity within the racial consciousness of the elves.

After a slight hesitation, he also reached toward one faint thread in his field of view and touched it carefully.

He felt nothing at all—but that did not surprise him.

After all, his ability to “see” the invisible threads right now was only something he had “borrowed” from Alice through the link of the flame. It was natural that he could not use it very well.

“Goathead,” Duncan called inwardly after a brief pause. “Can you feel anything?”

“No,” Goathead’s voice came at once, sounding a bit lost and flustered. “Sorry, Captain, I…”

“It’s fine. This isn’t your fault.”

Duncan cut him off. At the same time, he stepped to the edge of the deck and stretched his hand out over the side.

A wisp of ghostly green spirit-form flame gathered in his palm, then fell into the sea like water. The flame spread silently across the surface and flowed toward the floating invisible threads.

However, in the next second, the flame passed cleanly through every thread. Duncan felt no “feedback” at all, as if… those threads existed in a

dimension that could not be disturbed.

He frowned at the sight, but was not very surprised. He only murmured thoughtfully: “…So it really isn’t that easy.”

Just then, a long, mellow steam whistle from the distant sea suddenly broke his thoughts.

Duncan immediately looked toward the source of the sound.

He saw a towering silhouette appear on the far-off sea along with the whistle. It was as if a veil between sky and water had suddenly been lifted, and a colossal mass, about a quarter the size of a city-state, simply “popped” out of nowhere and began moving this way, slowing down as it came.

Then he gradually made out the huge vessel’s shape. Its edges were sheer like cliffs. White high walls ringed its base. On the higher ground within those walls stood buildings of many heights: clock towers, spires, and tall blocks. Those buildings, with their white outer walls and blue roofs, did not look very religious. Instead, they reminded him of the famous city university at the center of Lightwind Harbor—the two shared a faintly similar style.

Around that giant structure, Duncan also saw the silhouettes of other ships. Every one of them was a modern, advanced main battleship, yet in front of that enormous ark-ship, they looked very small. At first, he almost overlooked them.

At that moment, white mist began to rise from above the huge “moving city-state.” The academy buildings on its back spewed massive jets of steam from their rooftops. Soon after, the mellow whistle crossed the distant sea again and reached Duncan’s ears a second time.

The second whistle was some kind of signal, with a faintly friendly tone.

Duncan already realized what it was.

It was Truth Academy's pilgrimage ark and its escort fleet!

He had seen the Deep Sea Church's pilgrimage ark before, and that huge "moving city-state" had left a deep mark on him. He knew that the churches of the Four Gods each had their own giant ark, and their sizes were all roughly the same. The massive thing now rising on the distant sea matched the scale of the "Storm Cathedral ark-ship" he had seen in Pland, and the style of the buildings on its upper decks revealed which side it belonged to.

"Captain!!" Goathead's voice suddenly rang out in his mind, breaking Duncan's thoughts. The first mate sounded clearly shocked and a little tense. "It's a church pilgrimage ark!"

"I see it," Duncan answered calmly. "Why are you so nervous?"

"That's a church pilgrimage ark!" Goathead clearly could not understand how the captain could stay so calm. "That thing is hard to deal with—that ship really has a deity's direct protection…"

"Why would I need to deal with it?" Duncan replied casually. "It's not like I've gone to war with the churches of the Four Gods."

But Goathead still sounded very nervous: "But Lightwind Harbor is gone! That big Lightwind Harbor is just gone!"

Duncan felt baffled: "I wasn't the one who erased it."

Goathead fell silent: "…"

The poor first mate seemed to be completely stuck by the logic and did not know how to continue. Only a jumble of confused thoughts came through. Duncan ignored him, turned, and walked toward the helm on the aft deck, taking direct control of the Vanished.

The huge ghost ship “came to life” at once. The spirit-form sails swelled into being from emptiness, and then the great sailing warship turned with startling grace, heading straight for the distant “pilgrimage ark” that looked like a small city-state.

Duncan did not hesitate at all.

Goathead was startled by the captain’s decisiveness: “Captain?”

“We’re going over to say hello and exchange information. They clearly aren’t just passing by—Truth Academy’s pilgrimage ark must have come because of Lightwind Harbor’s distress signal,” Duncan said offhandedly as he steered the Vanished forward. “I know what’s making you nervous. Over the past century the Vanished indeed had some unpleasant history with the four churches, but you have to look at how things have changed.”

“We’ve already had a lot of dealings with several city-states and their churches. Personally, I think this kind of active, positive contact has worked very well. Remember what Lucretia mentioned? The churches of the Four Gods sent notices to the city-states, ordering every city and every Cathedral to cooperate fully with the Vanished fleet. That means they’ve already noticed the Vanished’s zeal in protecting the civilized world…”

Goathead was left stunned by Duncan’s words, but he still reacted quickly and reminded him worriedly: “But… what if? We’ve never had direct contact with Truth Academy’s pilgrimage ark, and Lightwind Harbor is still in this state. That fleet’s purpose isn’t clear, and if we just sail over like this and there really is some misunderstanding…”

Duncan said nothing. He only smiled and shook his head.

Spirit flame burned over his body, making his form shine like cast light, half-transparent. The Vanished cut through the waves in the “mist” woven from countless threads and sailed toward the distant Academy Ark. Under

the rippling surface lay the Vanished's hazy reflection—now slowly wrapped in ghost-green flame. Strands of fire flowed like water through the broken waves, dyeing the whole stretch of sea with a layer of dim green light.

"If there's no misunderstanding, then there's no misunderstanding. If there is a misunderstanding, then it isn't a misunderstanding—so, in short, there won't be a misunderstanding."

Chapter 631: Invitation and Contact

The two sides stopped very close to each other—close enough that landing boats could travel between the large ships quickly.

Duncan watched the massive pilgrimage ark with curiosity. He looked at the academy facilities and the many towers built across its upper levels. He saw lots of figures moving near the walls. Some were probably the Academy Ark's guards and sailors, while others, judging from their clothing, looked like ordinary scholars or apprentices. He also saw steam walkers—large spider automatons climbing along the ark's outer bulwarks. They seemed far more agile than any walking machine he had seen in other city-states, clearly made with a higher level of technology.

Duncan knew that the people aboard that pilgrimage ark were certainly observing the Vanished as well.

Ripples of light shimmered on the sea. A light breeze ruffled the surface, and the sinking evening sun laid a pale gold sheen over the rising waves. Yet mixed into that golden glow were faint streaks of ghostly green. That ghost-green water spread outward from the Vanished as its center, until it reached the edge of the pilgrimage ark—where it stopped. There, a sharp "boundary" appeared, and on that boundary line Duncan could clearly feel some kind of "resistance."

The ghost ship and the Cathedral ship faced each other in silence across the sea.

After they had held this standoff for who knew how long, Duncan glanced doubtfully at a nearby shadow and asked: “What are they waiting for?”

“Maybe they’re still watching how the Vanished moves?” Agatha’s voice came from the shadow, sounding a bit unsure. “But they should at least send some kind of contact…”

The steering platform fell briefly silent. Duncan thought for a moment, then spoke, sounding a little uncertain: “Tell me, is it possible they’re trying to hail the Vanished by radio?”

Agatha fell silent: “…Do we have a radio on board?”

“No, but I’ve always wanted to install one. Coming to Lightwind Harbor this time, I actually planned to do it…”

Agatha: “…”

Just then, flashes of light from the upper decks of the pilgrimage ark cut off the exchange between Duncan and Agatha. Along with the rhythmic signal lamps, Duncan also noticed flags waving near the lights.

In the end, it was still the traditional, reliable lamps and flags that did the job.

“They’re inviting the Vanished to come alongside and dock with the pilgrimage ark?” Duncan read the meaning of the signals and looked surprised. “They’re serious?”

“Captain, this could be a trap,” Goathead’s voice came at once through the mental link, filled with his usual conspiracies and natural wariness toward the church. “You must be careful.”

“I understand your caution, but at a time like this it’s not very likely,” Duncan shook his head. “Besides, trap or not, my plan was to meet the

people on that ark anyway—and now that they're inviting us first, that's even better."

As he spoke, he slowly steered the Vanished closer to the huge ark. At the same time, he watched the pilgrimage ark and the surrounding warships even more carefully, and, with the power of flame, spread his perception farther out over the sea.

Of course he would not drop even the most basic caution. Logically, he did not think this was a trap, but this was still direct contact with one of the top forces of the Four Gods' churches. Who could say what was running through the mind of the pope who served the God of Wisdom Rahm?

And Duncan believed that the people on the ark were probably having the same worries. They had invited the Vanished—but were they nervous?

They were nervous too.

From their point of view—who knew what the "ghost captain" of the Vanished was planning?

Since the Vanished had returned to the Mortal Realm, it had already made contact with many city-states and church forces. Duncan knew those contacts had had an effect. The churches of the Four Gods were trying to understand this ghost ship that had sailed back from Subspace. Sending Vanna aboard was proof of that, and it was indeed a friendly sign. But Duncan also knew very well that, to the world, the Vanished was still an unknowable symbol, full of riddles and danger.

To Duncan, the churches of the Four Gods were the same.

Caution, watching, testing, contact—even after building some level of communication, even after forming a bit of tacit understanding, both sides still had to step toward each other carefully again and again, confirming "safety" bit by bit. They had to see whether the ghost captain who returned

to the Mortal Realm really had human feelings, and whether the Vanished's recent actions were true goodwill or just a disguise driven by Subspace chaos. And Duncan had to see how much real trust and tacit understanding the other side was offering.

At the same time, he was also speaking with one of his followers.

Morris had once studied at Truth Academy—and his mentor back then was the very "pope" who commanded the Academy Ark.

This was exactly the tradition that set Truth Academy apart from the churches of the other three gods. The followers of the God of Wisdom took "passing down knowledge" as their core doctrine. Their priest system was built entirely on the roles of teacher and student, and even the pope was no exception.

Almost all outstanding scholars in this world had once studied at Truth Academy. The luckiest among them even had the chance to board the Academy Ark and become Pope Rune's students.

"…I think you can be at ease. I've talked with my mentor many times about the Vanished. Among the popes of the Four Gods, his attitude toward the Vanished should be the calmest, most rational and most objective…"

"I'm not very worried about your mentor's 'attitude.' I'm just a bit curious why Truth Academy's pilgrimage ark has come to Lightwind Harbor in person, and so quickly," Duncan replied in his mind. "Remember how big the commotion was in Pland before? The Storm Cathedral only rushed over after everything was already finished. In Frostholm, the Death Church's ark never showed up at all."

"Lightwind Harbor is close to the border. Most of the time, the church's pilgrimage arks patrol near the frontier, so it's normal for them to arrive

quickly," Morris explained. "Lightwind Harbor may have sent a call for help to the academy's headquarters many days ago. Also…"

He paused for a moment, then slowly went on a few seconds later: "Also, more than half the people on the Academy Ark are elves."

Duncan narrowed his eyes slightly.

The pilgrimage ark drew closer, this astonishing creation floating before the Vanished like a small city-state. Part of its "hull" grew larger and larger in his sight, until it almost formed something you could honestly call a "coastline."

Then guiding lights and flags lit up along that "coastline." Amid low rumbles and the deep growl of large steam valves venting pressure, Duncan saw a section of the edge of this very special Cathedral ship suddenly shift and transform. A large mechanical structure unfolded from its bulwark and extended down into the sea.

A dock appeared there—a dock where the Vanished could temporarily moor.

Duncan let go of the wheel.

The Vanished began to adjust its own position and angle. It carefully "studied" the mechanical dock extending from the Academy Ark, then finally moved slowly toward the gangway.

For some reason, Duncan felt that the Vanished's movements even carried a faint sense of… distaste.

But he soon turned his attention elsewhere.

He lifted his head and looked at the sky above the Academy Ark.

Once again, he "saw" that hazy, tentacled structure. Like a soul outside its body, a vast, indescribable, empty spirit-form stretched out from the ark-

ship and floated like cloud and mist over it, with countless arms and ever-changing shadows at its edges.

Duncan stared hard at those “phantoms” stretching out of the Academy Ark.

When the Storm Cathedral had visited the city-state of Pland before, he had seen something similar there too!

Back then, he had thought it was a kind of “power” from the deity worshipped by the Deep Sea Church—Storm Goddess Gamona, a symbol of the Deep Sea’s strength. But now… the Truth Academy’s ark-ship had it as well?!

Did the other churches’ ark-ships have it too?

Was this something all four ark-ships carried? What in the world was it?!

A storm of questions rose at once in Duncan’s mind. Just then, from the corner of his eye, he saw figures appear on the gangway that linked the Vanished and the Academy Ark.

He quickly put away his scattered thoughts and focused on the “visitors” coming down from the Academy Ark.

There were four steam walkers. They escorted a small group of people onto the gangway, then stopped halfway between the Vanished and the ark, crouching by the sides of the bridge and waiting. The small group kept walking toward the Vanished. Among them were guards in the academy’s knowledge guard uniforms and attendants dressed like apprentices. Walking at the very front was an old man in a scholar’s robe, short and plump.

Duncan recalled how Morris had described his mentor.

That should be the leader of Truth Academy, the God of Wisdom Rahm’s representative in the Mortal Realm, Morris’s mentor—Rune.

That “pope” had actually come out in person—with only a few followers, walking straight toward the Vanished?

Duncan’s thoughts moved, and the next second his body turned into a stream of fire. The fire swept across the deck and fell straight to the end of the gangway, where it gathered again into his form.

The group from the Academy Ark clearly jumped at the sudden flames in front of them. Instinctively, they moved to shield Rune. But he simply waved his hand calmly, then smiled at Duncan as he stepped out of the fire.

“It is very good to meet you, Captain Duncan Abnomar,” the elven old man said, nodding politely and gently. “This is our first meeting.”

“I’m happy to meet you too.” Duncan nodded back just as politely.

But just as he was about to say something else, he suddenly noticed a strange anomaly about the other man.

The pope’s body… looked faintly transparent!

Chapter 632: Nightmare and Rupture

Duncan noticed the anomaly on the elderly elf before him. He saw that the other man's body was turning half-transparent, as if he might disappear from this world at any moment.

The change in Duncan's expression clearly fell into the old elf's eyes.

"As you can see, Captain, some interesting changes are happening to me," Rune said calmly with a smile. He even raised his hand to show the palm where the transparency was worst. "A mighty power is trying to take me over to 'Her' side."

Duncan's expression changed slightly at once: "Atlantis's power— I didn't expect even you, the 'pope', to be affected."

"After all, I am also an elf. It seems that whatever is rooted deep in the soul of our race does not care whether I am a 'pope' or not," Rune said in a calm tone. "I felt that powerful invitation—Atlantis is calling all elves back to the Mother Tree."

Duncan frowned. He had found something that did not quite fit: "But you are still clear-headed. That is not the same as the other elves I heard about."

"Because I'm not going," Rune said with a gentle smile.

"…?" Duncan looked at him.

“As a ‘pope’, I should have some special privileges. At the very least, for a time, I can still refuse Atlantis’s ‘invitation’,” Rune said as he lifted his head to look past Duncan. “Captain, would you mind if I came aboard to talk? I know a little about the current situation.”

Duncan did not refuse. He stayed silent for a few seconds, then nodded. He stepped aside to make room while calmly turning his gaze on the old man’s eyes: “As long as your doctrine does not mind you stepping onto a Subspace Shadows ship.”

“The scriptures come from the god,” Rune said unhurriedly. He walked to the end of the gangway and stepped onto the deck of the Vanished without any concern, then went on: “But it is people who interpret them. I can smooth it over when I meet with the bishops later.”

The corner of Duncan’s mouth twitched. He suddenly realized this pope was not quite what he had imagined. Then he noticed that all the attendants Rune had brought were still standing on the gangway and did not seem to plan on coming aboard. This surprised him: “Are your attendants and guards not coming with you? You plan to board alone?”

Rune had already walked several steps ahead. He looked back when he heard Duncan: “They won’t come. Some things are better if fewer people know about them.”

This old gentleman did not look worried at all. Seeing how calm he was, Duncan had no reason to object. He waved to the people still on the gangway, then turned and walked to Rune’s side. Still, as they crossed the deck, he could not help asking one more thing: “You came here all by yourself. Aren’t you worried about your safety without any guards?”

Rune looked up at Duncan: “If you truly meant me harm, could a few guards really keep me safe on the Vanished?”

Duncan thought about it seriously and answered plainly: “They would have trouble keeping themselves safe.”

“Exactly. I am a practical man. That is the basic discipline of any scholar,” Rune said casually, then followed Duncan toward the captain’s cabin.

On the way, Duncan roughly explained the current situation to this pope. He told him about the disappearance of Lightwind Harbor and the state of the city-state.

As they were about to reach the aft deck, Rune stopped. He lifted his head and looked over the Vanished’s rail toward the wide sea on the other side of the hull.

That was where Lightwind Harbor had once been.

But now there was only sea water slowly turning golden under the sunset, and, far away, a glowing geometric body floating quietly on the surface.

Duncan could still see countless invisible strands floating above that sea, as dense as hair. But to Rune, the sea there was completely empty.

“It was already like this when I arrived,” Duncan said casually when he noticed Rune’s gaze. “You don’t think I made it disappear, do you?”

“…When we first reached this sea, some people did think so. If Banster were here, he would be even more certain,” Rune said after a pause, his tone a little odd. “Please understand, a whole city-state has vanished into thin air. That is truly hard to believe, and the Vanished is still on the scene. Even though we know this is related to the Nameless One’s dream, people cannot help letting their thoughts run wild.”

Duncan said nothing. He stepped forward, opened the door of the captain’s cabin, and gestured for Rune to enter.

With clear curiosity on his face, Rune followed Duncan into this place that, for the outside world, was wrapped in countless bizarre tales, horror, and mystery.

“Captain, you’re back!” Alice, who had been waiting in the cabin, rushed over first. She happily ran to Duncan, then suddenly stopped. “…Who is this old man?”

Rune stared in some surprise at the doll that had suddenly appeared in front of him.

But he reacted quickly and matched her to the information in his mind: “If I am not mistaken, this must be Miss Alice?”

“Yes,” Alice nodded a little and stared curiously at the strange old man who had just come in. “Who are you?”

“The God of Wisdom’s servant,” Rune said with a polite smile. “You can just call me Rune.”

“He is Mr. Morris’s teacher,” Duncan added casually at the side—he knew Alice would understand that better.

“Oh! Mr. Morris’s teacher! Then you must be amazing,” Alice said, suddenly enlightened. She quickly ran over to the small tea stove like she always did. “I’ll make some tea!”

Rune watched in amazement as the terrifying doll, labeled as being in a runaway state in official records, bustled around the room. He also looked curiously at the furnishings in the captain’s cabin. Then, suddenly, a strange feeling of being watched caught his attention. He turned his gaze without thinking and saw, on the chart table in the middle of the room, a jet-black wooden carving of Goathead lying quietly there—the eerie “sculpture” was fixing him with a gaze. Its eyes, like obsidian, were hollow and deep, and a faint, uncanny light flickered in that gaze.

Rune seemed to freeze. He stood still, staring at the strange black “wood carving” without blinking.

After who knew how long, Goathead finally moved. It suddenly spoke: “What are you looking at? Never seen a work of art?”

But Rune seemed to wake from a dream. The moment Goathead’s words fell, he let out a low cry and quickly turned his gaze away. He braced one hand on the table, carefully avoiding looking back at the “wood carving,” and raised his head to Duncan: “She saw it!”

Duncan reacted at once: “Atlantis?”

“Yes, Atlantis saw it. I… don’t know how to describe the feeling, but just now I felt Atlantis’s ‘gaze’ suddenly focus here. She was looking at this place through my eyes. She… I could not understand what she was trying to send. Confusion, fear, anger… countless chaotic emotions…”

He suddenly stopped and waved his hand in front of his eyes, as if trying to drive some unseen interference out of his mind. Duncan noticed that the old elf’s body had become a little more transparent in the last few seconds, but soon Rune returned to “stability.” He lifted his head, the chaos in his eyes slowly clearing: “She has left for now, but I don’t know how long I can hold her back. Captain Duncan, we have less time than I expected. Listen to me first.”

It seemed Rune had used a willpower no mortal could imagine to drive out the part of Atlantis that lingered in his mind. Then he sat down by the chart table and spoke quickly— “Atlantis is calling all the elves in the world. This call is rooted deep in our souls. While I was under its influence, I also touched part of her thoughts.

“I saw… a Doomsday, something that destroyed everything, burned deep into her memories. That Doomsday led to her gradual runaway state… Fear,

anger, and helplessness in the face of her own destruction—these things had slept in her mind for a long time. Now she is slowly waking up, so those sleeping fears and memories of Doomsday are waking up with her. But that is not the only reason…"

He stopped, as if it took great effort to steady his thoughts again. After resting for a few seconds, he went on: "In her anger, I also felt a strong emotion aimed at us elves. It was strange and confused, full of a sharp sense of tearing… I felt a strong will to protect. She ordered the elves to return to the World Tree to receive some kind of 'shelter.' But at the same time, she felt huge resistance and even… terror toward this 'protection,' as if she was treating us as some kind of…"

This time Rune paused even longer, as if he had to struggle to find a word that could describe the strong feeling he had "touched" in Atlantis. After opening his mouth several times, he finally spoke again: "Some kind of… not-quite monster…"

He slowly turned his head and looked at a point outside the window—that was the sea where Lightwind Harbor had vanished.

In theory, he could not see Lightwind Harbor, and he could not see the invisible threads floating above the sea.

But he kept staring in that direction, as if some invisible call was sounding in his mind, making the old elf look toward the World Tree that existed only in the race's memory.

"I can feel it…" Rune spoke softly, as if he were talking in his sleep. "She is going mad in this tearing pain, but… there is also…

"It feels like something else, on the 'other side' of that Doomsday. There seems to be another being that has gone mad… sending me a faint call…"

With a clatter, something fell to the floor by the small tea stove.

Alice looked up and stared at the window in fright.

“Captain! Those threads are moving!”

Chapter 633: Dream Sinking

The threads were moving.

Duncan heard Alice’s cry. He snapped out of his thoughts and looked up at the window. Then a sight he would never forget filled his eyes—

On the sea where Lightwind Harbor had once been, the invisible threads, dense as hair and woven like mist, began to change wildly. The long veil of “gauze-mist” slowly swelled and shrank, writhing as it shifted between real and unreal. It slowly reshaped into a form. The part on the sea surface drew back, gathered, and rose higher, while the structure floating in the clouds swelled outward, split into crisscrossing branches, and slowly drooped toward the edge of the sea like another sky.

A hard-to-describe feeling of pressure from a colossal thing came from that shifting phantom. The whole sea began to fall under the shadow of that invisible crown. Only then did Duncan finally understand what he was seeing—it was a tree.

The “threads” that had floated over the sea were twisting together like strands of hair into the shape of a huge tree—a World Tree big enough to cover the entire sea!

Rune pushed himself up from the table with difficulty. The old elf who had relied on his own will to resist Atlantis’s call now seemed close to his limit. He too stared out the window. Without Alice’s power, he still could not see the invisible threads, and that stretch of sea remained empty to him. But

suddenly, large patches of shadow appeared on the empty sea—the lines that had been invisible began to show outlines that the naked eye could see.

He saw the tree, the towering giant that was growing fast, spreading out from the elves' racial dream.

"That is…" Rune's eyes widened at once. Memories and feelings that had slept deep in his soul surged up like a tide, and he muttered without thinking: "Atlantis… Atlantis has come to take us home…"

But the next second, his eyes suddenly cleared again. Rahm's power dragged his mind back to the Mortal Realm. He pressed his forehead hard: "Captain Duncan, Atlantis's awakening has entered its next stage… She is remembering her original form…"

A long, clear steam whistle suddenly sounded from nearby. It was the Pilgrimage Ark at the edge of the sea warning the whole fleet. There was a note of urging in the whistle as well; the people left on the ark seemed worried about the pope's safety.

Rune lifted his hand and quickly traced a few glowing characters in the air.

Duncan noticed at once: "What are you doing?"

"I am ordering the ark and the escort fleet to move away from Atlantis at once," Rune said quickly. "There are still many elves on those ships. They may not be affected yet, but they cannot stay in this sea any longer."

Duncan asked right away: "What about you?"

"That is exactly what I… wanted to say," Rune answered. He seemed dazed for a second but soon recovered. "Take me into Atlantis's dream—to the deepest part of the dream. I need to speak directly with that 'Guardian'…"

"Talk?" Duncan frowned deeply. "Don't tell me you plan to rely on your eloquence and sincerity to persuade a mad 'Elder God' to wake up."

“No. I have another way. It might be able to affect her…” Rune said.

Duncan quietly watched the old elf for a moment. Only when a second whistle, the Cathedral ark’s signal to withdraw, came from nearby did he finally break the silence: “How can you be so sure I can take you into the depths of Atlantis’s dream?”

Rune steadied himself and met Duncan’s gaze: “Because the moment I made contact with Atlantis, I saw the Vanished. Even though it was sailing in the darkness at the border, I am certain that is proof you can communicate with Atlantis.”

As he listened to the old pope, Duncan’s expression did not change, but his heart suddenly stirred.

What Rune described… was what the world looked like from Atlantis’s “point of view”?

A plan that had only been vague before suddenly took shape. Duncan turned his gaze to the chart table beside him, to the keel sample lying on it.

Rune grew a little uneasy at Duncan’s sudden silence and could not help asking: “…You do have a way, don’t you?”

“…Things are a little different from before, but…” Duncan still stared at the block of wood on the table. Slowly, a small smile appeared on his face. “Yes, I have an idea, and I was just about to try it. I can give you a ride along the way. The only problem is… the journey may be a bit exciting.”

Rune froze: “…Exciting?”

“Have you ever ridden on a ghost ship, sailing through an Elder God’s nightmare?”

…

When the howl came from the street, Lucretia was asking Taran Ael to confirm the strange scene he had seen in the last moment of the Nameless One's dream, and the voice from Atlantis that he had heard while half out of his mind.

Taran Ael had said that before the Nameless One's dream ended, he saw the world being destroyed. That scene was very likely the one burned deep into the elves' racial memory, the memory of the Great Annihilation at the start of the Deep Sea era that generations of scholars had sought in vain. He had also said he heard a voice that seemed to be Atlantis's, and the anger and terror in that voice seemed to point to a secret. Lucretia felt she was already touching the final truth of this dream, but just as she was about to keep asking, a strange howl swept over the entire city-state.

She jumped to her feet and ran to the window.

The sight before her made even this "sea witch" lose her breath. She stood there, stunned.

The "sky" above the city was burning. Roaring flames swept across it, like huge waves rushing out from the depths of an endless nightmare. They rolled over the layered crowns of trees above Lightwind Harbor and the muddy, chaotic sky between the branches. The fire was like a blanket, covering everything. It shrieked and leaped down into every street under the canopy, pouring like a flood to devour every inch of land in sight.

It gave her a feeling—as if the forest that had stretched out from the dream had suddenly transformed into solid fire, and that fire had then begun to burn the whole city-state.

The moment the flames fell, explosions, screams, the crashes of Steam Walkers in runaway state slamming into buildings, and all kinds of loud, chaotic noise almost instantly filled the entire city-state!

The shocking change came so suddenly that Lucretia felt a strange, unreal sense of tearing. She stood at the window in a daze, staring at the scene outside. After two seconds, her gaze rose on its own, as if something were pulling it, toward the blazing sky.

In the flames that already covered the sky, she saw a huge structure slowly coming into view. It was like a solid Day of Ruin pushing down from the heavens, pressing inch by inch toward everyone's heads.

…What was that?

The question rose in Lucretia's mind without her even thinking it. The next second, a cry from behind finally snapped her out of her brief daze.

"By Rahm's name!" One of the knowledge guards stared at the window and cried out: "What is that thing?!"

Even Taran Ael, whose condition had been poor and whose head was full of noise and pain, pushed himself up from his chair. He wobbled over to Lucretia and looked out at the burning sky and the streets in chaos.

Confusion and fear filled the scholar's eyes. He seemed unable to imagine Lightwind Harbor falling into such horror so suddenly. Even though the forest that had spread out of the Nameless One's dream had already swallowed the whole city, the sight outside now still made him feel as if he had fallen into yet another layer of nightmare. He could not help muttering: "It really is a nightmare…"

"No, Master Taran Ael," Lucretia's voice came from beside him, pulling him out of his daze. He saw the sea witch turning her head, her eyes deep as the ocean. "This is a nightmare."

A brief look of confusion crossed Taran Ael's face, while the light of the flames slowly reflected in Lucretia's eyes.

She saw the room starting to fall apart. The figures in the room curled and twisted in the fire. She saw the light of the sky's flames pierce the roof and turn into cold beams of sunlight that swept through the air. She saw a huge tree appear in the distance—it rose from the sea, as if it were an extension of the city-state itself.

She stepped forward and put her hand on Taran Ael's shoulder.

"My father said that Lightwind Harbor has vanished from the Mortal Realm. There is only a blank space over that sea now.

"Mr. Taran Ael, we have never woken up from the start—the whole city is still asleep.

"But Atlantis is about to wake up from the dream…"

She pressed down slightly and pushed Taran Ael forward, who had frozen like a statue without her noticing.

"Come on. Let's go see what exactly Atlantis has been dreaming about."

The next second, under the blazing flames and the falling sky, Lightwind Harbor slowly and quietly fell apart.

At the last moment, as the flames swept over it, the city turned into bubbles, gleams of light, smoke, wind, and whispering voices. Its final shadow reflected on the calm sea. The remaining firelight and twisted, torn scene in that reflection looked like an illusion, slowly swallowed by the breaking waves.

Amid the rising and falling waves, a huge shadow was slowly growing up from the seabed—it seemed to be a giant tree.

And along the edge of that tree, which kept growing from the deep, another shadow, sometimes real and sometimes ghostly, was moving slowly.

It was a ghost ship, slowly rising into view.

Chapter 634:

Shirley felt that she had been sinking in darkness for a long time. She kept sinking, as if the whole world had suddenly turned into nothingness and she would fall into an endless sleep in this descent.

Until a huge force suddenly grabbed her arm, and Dog's voice rang directly in her mind: "Shirley! Wake up! Wake up! Don't sleep!!"

Shirley finally jolted awake from that dream of falling, and she almost sprang straight up from the spot: "Dog! Fire! The city is on fire again!"

That horrible scene of flames spreading across the sky still seemed to burn in her fading memories. The crushing fear of seeing an entire city swallowed by fire made her heart pound wildly. She could not remember how long it had been since she last had a nightmare like that. When she woke up, she was not even sure if she had truly awakened, or if she had fallen into another nightmare that was about to go up in flames.

But Dog's voice pulled her back from her panic: "Shirley, there's no fire. That was just a dream. There is no big fire here now…"

Shirley finally woke up completely. She shook her head. The scene in front of her was still a little blurry, but she could see lush green filling her vision and hear the sound of flowing water by her ear. She also saw Dog beside her. That let her relax at last. She leaned against Dog without thinking and took a few deep breaths: "That really scared me to death… So what was that just now… Why was the whole city suddenly on fire? Where are we now…"

“We are inside the Nameless One’s dream.” Lucretia’s voice suddenly came from the side, cutting Shirley’s muttering short at once.

Shirley looked up toward the sound. The strange blur in her sight finally faded away. She saw the “witch” Miss standing on a tree stump not far away. At the same time, she saw the thick forest around them and a stream flowing across a clearing in the woods not far ahead.

She stared blankly for two or three seconds before she finally understood their situation. She hesitated, straightened up, looked around at the forest, and spoke in a low voice: “We’ve come back to this forest again?”

Right after that, something else suddenly came to her mind. Her face changed at once: “Wait, what about the Mortal Realm over there?! We’re dreamwalking again now, so is the city ‘outside’ still burning…”

“There is no more Mortal Realm, Shirley. At least, not for Lightwind Harbor as it is right now. The Mortal Realm has already been completely swallowed by Atlantis’s power.” Lucretia looked calmly at the girl who was panicking again and explained patiently. “Do you remember? When my Father contacted us before, He told us that Lightwind Harbor in the Mortal Realm had already disappeared. From that moment on, we had already fallen into Atlantis’s dream along with the whole city. The forest that invaded the city, and the city that was invaded by the forest, were all part of the dream.”

Confusion still showed on Shirley’s face. She had not yet sorted out what was happening in front of her. Seeing this, Lucretia only shook her head lightly: “It’s like how the elves in the city would disappear after nightfall. Anything swallowed by Atlantis’s dream will vanish from the Mortal Realm. We always thought that only the elves could ‘disappear’ in this way. Now it seems… even an entire city can ‘dreamwalk’ under the influence of the Elder Gods.”

Shirley slowly widened her eyes. The fact that the whole city had already been swallowed by a dream made her feel a cold shock. After a long time, she finally spoke in complete confusion: “Then… what kind of situation is this now? How did we end up in this place again…”

“This is another layer of the dream. Shirley, look up. This is no longer the ‘forest’ we are familiar with.”

Listening to the witch’s words, Shirley finally noticed that something in the forest looked a little off. Only then did she realize the strange “sky” that showed through the treetops.

She hesitated, then raised her head.

An endless, astonishing structure came into her view. It hung above them, held up by branch-like masses as huge as mountain ranges in the sky.

It was as if another forest was hanging upside down above the heavens. The vast canopy wove itself into a second land above the plains and mountains. Vines that glowed with soft light and clusters of light, airy spores drooped from the treetops. Dotted gleams lit every corner beneath the canopy. Branches of unmeasurable length and thickness stretched across her vision and met in the farthest distance, becoming a “trunk” like a towering peak. Along the path of that trunk, countless “smaller branches” drooped down and fell all the way to the ground.

Where those “small branches” reached the earth, dense plants grew. Under the cover of the sky’s canopy, they formed a forest.

“This… this thing…” Shirley gaped, stammered several times, and finally managed to form words. “Atlantis!!”

“Yes. Atlantis. We have finally met her.” Lucretia raised her head and quietly gazed at the canopy that almost completely blocked out the sky, and at the faint shapes between the leaves that looked like man-made buildings

or settlements. “This is the World Tree that slumbers deep in the elves’ racial memory… It is even more magnificent than I imagined.”

“Wait, give me a second. I’m all mixed up. I need to sort this out…” Shirley said quickly. At the same time, she could not help but look up again at that amazing giant tree that seemed big enough to cover the whole world. “We’ve come down to a deeper layer of the Nameless One’s dream, and the real Atlantis is sleeping here. Then what? Are we going to talk to this tree and see if she can keep sleeping?”

Lucretia did not answer. Her face turned serious and her mind sank.

“Rabby.”

The rabbit’s voice answered in her heart at once: “Rabby is listening~”

“What is happening on that ship right now? Are those cultists doing anything?”

“Rabby was just about to report to you. Things seem a little strange here…” The rabbit’s voice sounded very low, as if it was hiding from someone’s sight while answering carefully. “Those cultists suddenly all hid in their cabins. Rabby heard them talking… They said the Saint felt a bad omen in fate, so all actions are stopped for now. They also said the Ender sent a warning that a new Great Hollow is about to appear, and they must move away quickly…”

“A bad omen? Moving away from the Great Hollow?” Lucretia’s eyes changed slightly. “You mean those cultists sensed some danger and are running away?”

“It seems so. The ship is running at full speed in one direction now. Before this, it was only drifting slowly.” Rabby spoke in a cautious whisper. “Mistress, Rabby suddenly feels a little scared. Did Rabby get exposed? Did those cultists sense Rabby and get scared away…”

“No. You are not that important.” Lucretia answered without the slightest hesitation. “You are not even a match for that ‘Saint’. That ‘Saint’ must have gotten some other piece of information…”

“Then… what should Rabby do now?” The rabbit’s voice really did sound a little panicked. This evil spirit that was so good at moving inside nightmares seemed to be heavily affected in the Mortal Realm. “Those cultists don’t seem to plan on entering the Nameless One’s dream again. Rabby has no way to return to your side through the dream…”

“Stay hidden and behave yourself. I will come and get you later,” Lucretia said quickly. “Don’t worry, I will appear in front of you. And if I cannot find you, then my Father will appear in front of you. Don’t forget, you have seen Him before. Do you understand what I mean?”

As soon as she finished speaking, the Nightmare Rabbit let out a near shrieking scream: “Rabby understands!!!”

Lucretia ended the link with a blank face.

Shirley was still standing nervously beside her, as if she were waiting for the witch’s answer.

“Those Annihilators seem to have sensed something. They have paused their actions,” Lucretia exhaled softly and said to Shirley. “We still don’t know whether there is any change in the actions of the other group, the Suntists.”

Shirley thought for a moment after hearing this, then spoke, not quite sure: “So that means we don’t have to worry about running into those Annihilators here?”

Lucretia just looked at her calmly. Two seconds later she spoke: “No. It means the changes in this dream have already gone beyond those cultists’

plan. They have once again made a huge mess that even they cannot clean up. And we… are now inside that mess."

Shirley was startled by the slightly gloomy tone of this "sea witch". She froze for a moment. Just then, a faint rustling sound suddenly caught her attention.

The sound came from the direction of the stream. At first, it just sounded like ordinary water.

But soon, a strange noise rose within the sound of running water. That noise spread outward, and it seemed to start affecting the soil, stones, and shrubs along the banks…

Shirley saw fleshy tentacles rising out of the stream.

The soil began to writhe like the skin of a soft-bodied creature.

In the shadows in the bushes, something with sharp teeth was chewing on something.

And on the tree closest to her, at the tips of the lush green branches, the leaves slowly opened their eyes.

Shirley slowly took in a cold breath.

The whole forest seemed to have started to wriggle.

She finally let out a sharp, powerful scream: "I know why those cultists didn't come back – run!!"

…

Vanna opened her eyes in the middle of wind and sand.

The memory of the city suddenly going up in flames still lingered in her mind. The noise and explosions from the streets still seemed to echo in her

ears. But after a long stretch of darkness and falling, she realized she had once again returned to that familiar place.

“Traveler, we meet again.”

A familiar voice came from beside her, and the blowing sand died down along with it. Vanna raised her head and saw, once more, the old giant in the tattered robe.

She understood what was going on at once.

She had fallen from the dreamwalking city down into the deeper layers of this dream.

“This will be the last time we meet, traveler,” the giant said again.

Chapter 635:

This time, the wind in the desert seemed more violent than ever before.

Chaotic gusts swept again and again across the dunes scattered with jagged rocks. Dust rose into the air and swirled dozens of meters high. In the distance, a huge yellow-brown “wall” was slowly rising into the sky. A greater storm was brewing inside that wall, as if it were gathering power strong enough to sweep across the whole world.

Yet all this restless wind and sand stopped sharply just a few meters away from Vanna and the giant. The dust that had been lifted circled around them, like the view from the eye of a storm.

Vanna noticed the change in the surroundings at once. She stared in shock at the roiling dust in the distance, especially that faraway sandstorm that was rising from the ground like a wall to the sky. She had never seen such a sight before, and for the first time she felt uneasy: “What is that?”

The old giant in the tattered robe lowered his head slightly and looked gently into Vanna’s eyes. “It is a storm, traveler. A storm you yourself will raise.”

“A storm I will raise?” Vanna froze, staring at the giant in confusion. “When did I ever…”

“Not yet. But soon. Time has started flowing again, traveler. It is flowing in every direction. Do you feel it? This world is changing. After such a long stillness, this stone that was buried and bound under dust is finally about to start rolling again.”

Vanna listened, stunned, as the giant suddenly began to speak these vague, puzzling words. She drew her own guesses from them, but before she could ask, the giant waved his hand at her: “Don’t ask too much, traveler. This place is finally heading toward its end. The more you learn about it at this moment, the more tightly you will be bound to it. I do not want you to become the next soul wandering this desert.”

At last, Vanna saw something different in his words and in those eyes that burned with dim yellow fire.

This “deity who had lost his memory” had come to say goodbye.

“Come with me, traveler,” the giant beckoned to her. “Walk with me one last time, and let us put a period at the end of this journey.”

Vanna paused for a heartbeat, then quickly followed the giant’s steps and asked as she walked: “Where are you taking me? What exactly is happening here?”

“We are going back to that ‘big pit’,” the giant slowed his pace and lowered his head a little. “I have started to remember some things. What I have been looking for is there… and maybe what you want is there too.”

In a sudden swirl of wind and sand, the figures of Vanna and the giant vanished together into the depths of the desert.

…

The Sun had almost completely fallen below the horizon.

Upon the vast, boundless sea, only the huge luminous geometric body still floated quietly on the surface. The endless sunlight it shed spilled out gently and ran along the small waves into the farthest distance.

Lightwind Harbor, which had once been bathed in this sunlight, had already vanished from the sea. In the place where Lightwind Harbor used to lie, an

astonishing vision now stood tall. Countless strands of invisible things, as fine as hair, rose from the sea and tangled between sky and water, forming the projection of a tree even larger than the city itself.

This giant tree, half real and half unreal, was still growing. It seemed to still be drawing nourishment from the vanished Lightwind Harbor. Every second, it moved a little more from illusion toward reality. Each breeze that passed, each wave that rolled, made its trunk a bit clearer and its grand canopy a bit more solid. Now, standing in the sunlight that filled the sea, it towered over everything and blocked out the sky. Even the grand ark of the Cathedral floating on the distant sea looked like a “small boat” beside it.

The fleet of Truth Academy had already been ordered to withdraw from Atlantis’s projected range. The ark and its escorting warships were now circling on the sea outside the tree’s shadow.

But within the range of the great tree’s projection, on the sea under that towering canopy, a sailing warship wrapped in blazing ghostly fire was heading straight toward the “trunk”.

Its half transparent spirit form sails had already been raised. Invisible force filled them and pushed the Vanished forward, driving it toward the distant World Tree that rose like a mountain to the sky. In the flames, the huge ghost ship groaned in a deep, unsettling way, as if it were under heavy pressure, as if it were resisting a power that rejected it.

When the Vanished sailed to within twelve nautical miles of the trunk, the expected “rejection” appeared.

The waves rose higher and higher, building into a storm. Wave after wave surged from Atlantis’s direction and crashed hard against the bow of the Vanished, at times washing over the deck. Howling wind and thunderous booms came from the direction of the great tree. Each roar sounded as if it would shatter this ghost ship that kept pressing forward through the storm.

Within that ceaseless onrush of power, there was almost a solid feeling of resistance and… anger.

Atlantis did not like this ship. She did not like this ghost ship whose keel had been made from her branch and then reborn upon Saslokar's spine.

She felt confusion, anger, and even fear because of it.

Yet the crashing waves and the World Tree's roar outside the hull barely affected the stability within the ship.

Duncan walked down the steps, passing through dim, long corridors and slanted, ancient stairways. He crossed storerooms where the light was strangely inverted and passed cabins that made eerie noises, going step by step toward the deepest part of the ship.

In one hand he held the consecrated lantern that shed a faint green flame. In the other he held the "square timber" taken from the city of Pland.

He could feel the wood in his hand giving off a slight heat and tremor. This "sample", cut from the Vanished's original keel, seemed to sense something and was growing more and more restless.

Agatha's voice came from the shadows beside him: "The wind and waves outside are very strong. Atlantis is trying to stop the Vanished from getting close."

"It's almost quiet down here," Duncan just smiled. "Looks like the soundproofing in this part of the ship is pretty good."

"Alice tied Your Eminence Rune to a pillar with a rope. She said she was afraid the old Mr. would get thrown off the ship. Your Eminence Rune is not in good shape and could not resist… I tried to persuade her, but Alice wouldn't listen. She said this is basic common sense when going to sea, and that she's an old sailor on this ship now…"

“…As long as she’s happy,” Duncan kept walking. “What about the ropes, are they happy?”

“…They should be very happy. It’s not often they get the experience of tying the Pope to a ship.”

“That’s good then.”

Duncan said this lightly, then pushed open the last door leading down to the bottom deck.

The broken structure of the Vanished’s lower hull appeared before him.

No matter how fiercely the storm raged on the sea above, this layer of the “bottom deck”, half submerged in subspace, stayed as silent as ever. The shattered hull still floated quietly in the void. Chaotic streams of light from subspace flowed without order through the great cracks in the hull, just as they had a century ago, and just as they did now, a century later.

Duncan walked slowly to the center of this broken deck and stopped beside the largest fissure.

Agatha’s form rose at his side. She spoke with a hint of caution: “Can this really work?”

Duncan lowered his head and gazed at the crack under his feet and the flowing light within it.

“The Vanished’s original keel was made from Atlantis’s branch. Later, Saslokar’s spine replaced that keel and, with the divine authority of the King of Dreams, reshaped the Vanished that subspace had swallowed through a kind of ‘phase inversion’. So in a certain sense, the Vanished is another Atlantis.”

He bent down slowly and set the block of wood on the floor in front of him.

“Memory and dream. Saslokar wandered along the border between the real and the unreal. He created Atlantis in a dream and then rebuilt the Vanished in a dream. He drew everything from his own memories. The only problem was that he did not remember himself. He did not even know that he could dream.”

Duncan lightly tapped his finger on the surface of the wooden block.

A small green flame jumped up from one corner of the wood and, in the blink of an eye, consumed the whole block. In the surging spirit form fire, it took on the same ghostly, transparent texture as Duncan’s body.

“Saslokar was the first of the Dreamless. In the most heretical teachings, the simplest truth is often hidden.”

Duncan straightened, then kicked the flaming block of wood toward the fissure that led into subspace.

It tumbled over the edge of the hull and vanished almost at once into that dark, chaotic space, disappearing into the shifting currents of light.

A strange creaking sound began to rise from far away.

“So the key to entering the deep part of Atlantis’s dream was never to wake Atlantis herself. Atlantis is already awake. She does not need to be awakened.

“The one we must wake is Saslokar, the spine that is soaking in subspace.

“We must let Saslokar and Atlantis talk to each other. After all these long years, we must let this ‘Dreamless’ one realize that he is dreaming.”

The strange creaking noise rose to a peak. Then, all at once, dim emerald flame surged up from the cracks in the broken hull.

The spirit form fire rushed through the whole deck. Wherever the flames passed, the great fissures began to close and fade at a speed visible to the

naked eye. The broken hull began to slowly mend, and the Vanished's lower structure gradually became whole again.

Before the largest crack healed, Duncan caught a glimpse of the scene beneath it from the corner of his eye.

That was the Vanished's true "ship bottom", the real lower hold that wrapped around the keel.

A huge, desolate spine of an Elder God floated in subspace, sailing through the chaotic void.

Fresh green branches were winding out from the gaps in that skeleton, spreading along the backbone as the fire flowed over every part of it.

"Now the two keels have become one."

Duncan spoke softly.

In front of him, the last fissure in the Vanished's lower deck slowly closed.

He lifted his head and called out in his heart: "Saslokar."

Goathead's voice answered at once: "I am here, Captain."

"Full sail. Top speed. We're going to find your Little Sapling."

"Aye, Captain!"

Chapter 636: Sailing in the Elder Gods' Nightmare

The Vanished began to accelerate toward Atlantis. It charged ahead through waves that rose higher and higher, and into the terrible howls and storms rolling from the direction of that giant tree. Wrapped in blazing fire, the ghost ship started its assault.

Atlantis seemed to notice this sudden change. Its instinctive resistance to the Dream Invasion immediately stirred. Towering waves roared across the sea. The water influenced by the giant tree turned into sky-high walls, as if covered in fangs and blades, crashing down toward the bow of the Vanished with crushing force. In the scream of the waves, countless hazy figures appeared in the storm. They looked like an ancient army, mixed with warped visions of birds and beasts twisted beyond recognition. They surged through the gaps between the waves like a collapsing mountain, rushing at the burning ghost ship in the gale.

However, the Vanished did not avoid the oncoming storm at all. Its sails billowed even more, and its speed increased.

ghostly green flames burst from every seam of the decks, every cabin window, and every gunport on the ship, as if they meant to set the entire sea on fire. That living blaze skimmed over the ocean and crashed straight into the storm made of nightmare phantoms.

The towering waves burned, steam rolled up and opened huge gaps, and the blades hidden in the wind and spray were swallowed by an invisible power.

They vanished with the next gust, turning into harmless mist. The phantoms in the storm turned into true illusions in the fire.

They passed harmlessly through the hull of the Vanished. The spirit form fire did not harm them, and they could not touch the Vanished. Only in the ship's trailing wake of fire did these phantoms slowly pause, as if waking from a long dream. Silently, they faded away on the wind.

After that, the Vanished sailed into a greater storm, with more phantoms and nightmares closer to the true essence of Atlantis.

Just as a person could never tell when a dream truly began, after an instant too small for any sense to notice, the world outside the Vanished fell into murky darkness. The Boundless Sea was gone. The sky was gone. Even the "sunlight" that had spread from the distant sea had disappeared without anyone knowing when it left.

Around them, only storm-visions kept rolling in the dark, along with huge "tunnels" that appeared and vanished inside the storm, woven from countless vines and roots. The Vanished raced forward through one of these unspeakable tunnels.

After another instant too small to notice, sound vanished as well.

The world outside the Vanished became silent.

Yet the storm-phantoms were still there. They just churned in silence, which made them even more eerie and terrifying than before.

The Vanished sailed on through the tangled plant structures. The entire ship seemed to float in a void. Far ahead, in that void, only the vast shadow of Atlantis remained.

It looked like the last solid thing left in the world, as if after the world had collapsed and all things had fallen into silence, it was the one, final tree.

Or perhaps the very first tree.

Rune felt a little better. After they passed that unnoticeable “Dreamwalking moment”, or perhaps after the ship itself had gone through some kind of “change”, he found that the constant calling in his mind suddenly weakened. He felt his thoughts slowly becoming stable again. He could even hear the beating of his heart in his chest.

He lowered his head and saw that his body really was recovering bit by bit.

Looking out the window, he could see that enormous tree stretching for thousands of miles through the darkness.

Even though they were still trapped in this dangerous, terrifying “dream of the Elder Gods”, and even though he knew Atlantis was still trying to “protect”—or rather, to kill—every elf in the world, the old man still could not help but mutter under his breath: “…So beautiful…”

A voice answered from nearby: “Yes, very beautiful…”

Rune turned toward the sound and saw that the strange Goathead on the chart table was staring out the window with a sigh. Pale green flame flowed and rose through its wooden body, and a tongue of fire gathered beneath it like a blurred, twisted spine, running along the table and linking it to the deck below.

“At the beginning, I planted her in the dark—just like this,” the eerie wooden Goathead went on softly. It seemed lost in memory, carefully picking up the pieces buried deep in its mind. “Back then she was not this big… she was just a little sapling, crooked and bent, even a bit… ugly.

“At that time, I did not know what she would become, or what she ought to become. She shaped herself. All I did was let her grow, and keep growing.

“Then I learned to imagine more things. More trees. Plants that grew together with the trees, and all kinds of creatures living among them… I

placed them all through that darkness. After a while, the darkness faded, and the world began to grow rich and full. Many things… beyond my first imagination started to happen. Overall, it was interesting—much more interesting than an endless, meaningless emptiness.

“So some intelligent beings that grew out of the forest gave me a name. They said I was the ‘creator’.

“But I did not really understand that title. I did not understand much of what they said. They did many strange things that I could not understand either.

“They gathered together to dance. They piled their harvest at the feet of a billy goat carved from roots. They raised great waterwheels on the river and decorated them with bright ribbons. When at last they learned how to fly, they leapt from the branches of Atlantis in huge flying machines and glided over the hills, landing at the edge of Atlantis’s gaze amid cheers…

“They said it was to please the great creator, so the creator would not leave.

“But I did not understand what they were doing. I was not interested in their… performances and gifts at all. I never was.

“But when I saw how happy they were, I thought it was a good thing.”

Rune fell quiet. His eyes slowly opened wider as he stared at the unsettling Goathead on the table, his expression filled with disbelief.

He opened his mouth, but the tangle of feelings in his chest choked off all words. Only a strange sound came from his throat.

A sudden crackling explosion in the captain’s cabin cut off his next move and his next line.

Pale green spirit form fire flared out of thin air. A tall figure took shape in the flames. Duncan stepped out of the fire and looked straight at Goathead: “You remembered everything?”

“Broken, chaotic. Only vague impressions and a few flickering images,” Goathead answered with a soft creak of wood, slowly turning his gaze toward Duncan. “I can feel that many other ‘fragments’ are scattered in other places.”

“Planning to gather them all?” Duncan asked offhandedly.

“…It does not matter,” Goathead said after two seconds of silence. To Duncan’s surprise, he shook his head. “At least it is not something to think about right now.”

“…All right.” Duncan gave Goathead a long, deep look, then turned toward the window. “Get ready to make contact. We are close to the trunk.”

“Will you take the helm yourself?” Goathead asked.

“No,” Duncan shook his head. “If I took the helm, we might never find where Atlantis is hiding. Since you have remembered part of it, you keep steering. I think that part of your ‘memory’ is enough to lead us in the right direction.”

“Understood,” Goathead replied simply.

To be honest, Duncan found this sudden brevity of his a bit hard to get used to.

But he soon pushed that stray thought aside.

The Vanished began to pass through the layered, silent storm phantoms and the tunnels and Veil woven from countless vines and roots. The ghost ship that had wandered many times along the dark edge of the Veil now finally found the correct way forward.

Duncan turned his head and glanced at Rune, the pope.

After a brief, slightly awkward moment of eye contact, he waved to Alice, who was still off in her own thoughts nearby: “Come here and untie the old

gentleman…”

“Oh.” Alice answered at once and, a little regretfully, went over to “untie” the elven elder who was still bound to the pillar.

Rune’s mouth twitched slightly. Trying to hide his embarrassment, he spoke in a calm tone: “Actually, I think it is fine. Miss Alice’s methods also have a certain… professionalism to them…”

He had only spoken half his sentence when a violent tremor suddenly swept through the entire ship.

It felt as if the moving Vanished had crashed straight into some invisible giant mass. A shock unlike any before slammed in from the bow, along with a harsh screeching noise that made it seem as if the ship might break apart. The masts shook wildly. The spirit form sails flashed with blinding light as they flickered, and the fire flowing across the deck exploded with a sharp bang.

Duncan reacted the instant the unseen impact hit. He slapped his hand on the chart table before him, using the spirit form flames to steady the whole ship, and shouted quickly: “Tie him back up!”

This time Alice moved faster than ever: “Got it!”

“Wait, you two!” Rune only had time for one shout before Alice had tied him up again, tight and secure. In his poor state, the pope was no match for the living doll aboard the Vanished.

Almost at the same moment, Duncan caught sight of something outside the window, in the dark void around Atlantis.

spirit form flames burst from the Vanished, as if they had “smelled” something. They spread wildly into the darkness. In the overlapping glow of the spreading spirit flame, he saw… shadows even larger than Atlantis itself.

Chapter 637: Collision

There was a shadow—a shadow outside Atlantis—that had always floated in this vast dark space woven from Atlantis's dreams and memories.

Now, for the first time, Duncan saw it.

"In Rahm's name!" Rune's eyes went wide as he stared at the huge structure that finally appeared above the dark space in the glow of the pale green flames. He cried out: "What is that thing?!"

Duncan did not answer. He only walked to the window, his expression growing unusually grave as he fixed his divine gaze on that dark structure. It seemed to be pressing down on Atlantis from above, yet frozen in a single moment in time. After a while, his eyes changed slightly, as if he had suddenly understood something.

"The Great Annihilation… So that is how it was…"

…

corruption and distortion were spreading through the forest, across the land, and over the whole world.

Some invisible thing was soaking into this ancestral homeland of the elves. Wherever it spread, the earth writhed and heaved like swollen flesh. Fangs and eyeballs opened in the shadows. Trees grew wild and rampant, then dissolved and rose like flames. Everything seemed to lose its old order and change into something else, in a wild, nightmarish frenzy.

Sharp, terrible shrieks and howls swept through the forest without a pause, rushing past the huge crown of Atlantis, echoing across heaven and earth as if to tear at the soul.

Shirley stared in shock at the ground below. She watched a land that had been lush and full of life only a moment ago turn, in the blink of an eye, into an absurd hell that even a nightmare could not describe. She stared at the deep, gaping maws in the forest and the pulsing flesh and shadows, and she instinctively grabbed the raised edge of the “paper boat”.

“This thing really is not going to fall, right?”

She looked again at the “little boat” folded from paper beneath her feet and asked the Miss Witch at her side in a very uneasy tone.

Not long ago, when the whole forest suddenly broke out in terrifying “corruption” and all paths of retreat were cut off, Lucretia had taken out a sheet of paper right in front of her, folded it into a small boat, and pulled her aboard. Shirley could not understand at all how this strange “witchcraft” worked. She only knew that the boat now floated above that horrifying land, and the feel of paper under her feet made her afraid to even breathe too hard.

Even Dog, beside her, had carefully tucked in his paws and curled up into a ball, as if terrified of accidentally scratching the bottom of the paper boat.

“I have never fallen off it,” Lucretia said. She had already taken out more white paper and was folding more strange shapes with practiced hands without even looking up. “If you are really that worried, just close your eyes and pretend you are lying on the sofa at home.”

“How am I supposed to do that?!” Shirley cried without thinking. Then the little boat rocked suddenly in the wind and she let out another yelp. After

that, she noticed what Lucretia's hands were doing. "What are you folding now?!"

"soldiers. The 'Winged Flying Troopers' Ginny Hadeway described in City in the Clouds," Lucretia said casually. "We need to know what is happening in other places. And if we really run into enemies, we will need some fighting power to protect this boat."

As she spoke, she tossed the finished paper figures into the air beside the boat. Several finely folded paper people spread their wings in midair, their size quickly growing to match that of real humans. They bowed toward Lucretia, then flew off into the distance.

Shirley stared at this scene with her mouth hanging open. Just as she was about to say something, a voice suddenly seemed to slip straight into her head, cutting off her conversation with Lucretia: "…First, there was the 'corruption'. At the edge of the world, things started to become strange and terrible…"

Shirley and Lucretia looked at each other at the same time. They had both heard the voice. It sounded young, like a little girl's voice.

It was the voice of Atlantis.

The howling wind kicked up more dust. The sandstorm in the desert had somehow faded away, leaving only chaotic dust and grit swirling in the air, blurring their sight and twisting the distant view.

"When the weather first began to change, some scholars already gave their warnings. They called on people to prepare—but what should they prepare for?"

The voice of the giant sounded through the storm, deep and steady, like stone standing firm in the wind.

Vanna stood in the endless sand and looked toward the distant "tower".

She had followed the giant back to this place called the “archive”, back to this great pit that symbolized the End of civilization. She did not know why the giant had brought her here, but she could feel that some world-shaking change was happening. With this “archive” at its center, something terrible was tearing open the Veil.

A ripping sound suddenly came. The roar was so huge it seemed it could shatter mountains.

Vanna looked up in shock at the giant red crack in the sky, at the crimson light that marked the End. In the rolling blood-red glow she saw shifting shadows, rising and falling in waves. The thing that had destroyed this world finally showed a hint of its true form before her eyes.

Fire appeared in the forest. It had no clear source. It was as if, in a single instant, countless trees had all turned into blazing Sacred beacon Torches. A tide of destruction rushed out in a heartbeat and began to burn the World Tree that blanketed the land.

Shirley watched in terror as the flames spread through her field of vision. Everything—the warped land, the once-lush forest, the shadows in the air, the tentacles and flesh that had been crawling through heaven and earth—all of it was swallowed by fire in an instant.

She heard a tremendous noise, the screaming of countless living beings in the flames. Then she heard a terrible thunder that did not come from the sky, but from the branches of Atlantis itself breaking amid flame and distortion, crashing down on the earth like a range of falling mountains.

The paper boat rocked wildly in the roaring heat. As the whole world burned, Shirley instinctively curled up on the little boat. Curled there, she looked up at the sky. She saw the branches and leaves at the edge of Atlantis breaking off and falling, wrapped in roaring fire, past the boat on

all sides. As the crown of the tree collapsed with a deafening crash, she finally saw the sky's true shape.

Her vision was filled with suffocating, horrifying shadows. For a moment, she felt as if her heart had stopped.

She heard Atlantis speaking in the depths of her heart—or perhaps it was the entire world, telling her of the ruin and death that had come in ages beyond count.

"…Then the sky fell. Something invisible struck our world, slowly struck our world… We could not see it, could not understand it, could not even think about it… And you? You who were born After the Darkness, you who grew out of it—can you see it?"

Vanna's eyes went wide. She watched the blood-red crack in the sky slowly spread. The whole sky tore open like a broken eggshell, then sank inward toward its center in a way that made her shiver. After that, a sea of fire pressed slowly down from the shattered heavens.

"As their 'god', I felt 'its' approach before they did. I felt something invisible drawing near our world. I felt the end of history. A crack appeared on the Chronicle Pillar in my hands. After that, nothing was recorded. The flames… went out at the edge of my sight."

A low, oppressive howling and a strange creaking noise came from both sky and earth, as if the world itself was letting out its last groan. At last Vanna understood what she was seeing. At last she understood the "answer" the giant had never been able to grasp.

A tall figure stepped into view at the edge of her vision, coming to the rim of the great pit.

Vanna saw the giant standing there, head raised, staring up at the sky.

“From fire and stone it began. With fire and stone it will end. Traveler, I can feel it. ‘It’ has come again… You see it, do you not? You see it more clearly than I do… because you come from a different time-stream than mine. You come from After the Darkness. You have eyes born after that time. You can understand it…”

On the Origami Skiff, in the sight of Shirley and Lucretia, the inverted land hanging over them sank lower and lower. At last they could clearly see many of its features.

For a moment, Shirley felt as if she saw ranges of mountains and rich rivers on that upside-down continent. She saw great stone cities standing among the hills and plains, saw huge canals and long roads linking countless points of light. Under those lights lay wide, fertile fields.

But in the next instant, she saw that land fall into desolation. After a strange “boiling” illusion, it became a world of deserts and rocky wastelands.

Another world was pressing down.

The falling land from the sky struck the crown of Atlantis first.

In silence, the final collapse of all things began to spread from that single point of contact, reaching out to swallow the whole world.

In the ever more chaotic storm of sand, before Vanna’s eyes, the huge tower that symbolized “The Last Man in the World” began to change.

It started to sway and crack. The upper layer, which had looked like blackened stone, split open. The pieces fell away, revealing a kind of pale gray “skin” beneath.

The tower began to shrink, as if time itself were flowing backward. Bit by bit, it drew in on itself, turning back into the shape of a “man”.

An upside-down, burning forest now filled the whole sky. Another continent had pressed down onto this world. In those blazing woods, Vanna finally saw some of the landscapes her companions had once described to her, from their own actions in the dreams of the Nameless One.

The “tower” finally collapsed.

At the moment when the whole world remembered its final Doomsday, he remembered his first shape.

He became a man.

A Senkin, with skin like stone and lines like metal running over his body.

He kept shrinking. Soon, he would be so small that Vanna would no longer be able to see him clearly at this distance.

He seemed to be crying out in terror. In that last minute before the Great Annihilation, this “man” who had been frozen in time for ages at last took a step along the time-stream.

“Traveler,” the giant’s voice came. The old deity in his tattered robe leaned down toward Vanna. He drove the huge Gatekeeper’s cane firmly into the ground. Then he reached into his robes with his other hand and placed something before Vanna. “Take it.”

Vanna stared in shock at what the giant had given her.

It was a blazing, radiant thing, quietly burning in the river of time.

The Sun.

She looked up, but before she could ask her question, the giant gently shook his head. “You can take it now, Traveler. I remember now. I remember everything… Our Sun is free. Take it. It should not lie trapped in this dream any longer.”

Vanna reached out her hand, a little dazed. The bright little sphere dropped into her palm.

It gave off a warm heat.

The giant smiled, slowly straightened up, and turned away.

“What are you going to do?” Vanna asked in confusion behind him.

“Make sure he is not afraid.”

“Wait—”

“It is all right, Traveler. Every journey must end. One day, we all have to say goodbye… because Tarrigan is dead. He died a very, very long time ago.

“And I will give you that Gatekeeper’s cane as well, as a keepsake.”

The giant never looked back. He only waved his hand, then stepped toward the deep pit.

With every step, his body grew larger.

But with every step, his figure became more and more faint.

The ruin called the “archive” also faded with the giant’s footsteps.

The God of Recorded History finally vanished into the storm. The last man ever written into history vanished as well, in the slow and unstoppable collision of two worlds.

In that endless waste of sand and wind, Vanna slowly lifted her head.

The burning Atlantis hung high over this world.

It was now the final second of the Great Annihilation.

The world of the Senkin ended in its final impact with Atlantis.

Chapter 638

Another continent hung upside down in the sky, slowly falling. The two worlds were being destroyed by a “slow collision” beyond understanding. It was some kind of impact beyond the Mortal Realm, not just a simple physical touch. After she saw the twisting, chaos, and madness spreading through the forest, Lucretia faintly realized this truth.

If this had been another time, she would gladly have thrown herself into a long and difficult study. She would have gone to speak with Scholars from the city-states, gathered their sharp minds together, and tried to figure out every secret behind this collision.

But now was clearly not the time.

The Origami Skiff shook wildly in a violent shock, like a little skiff caught in a storm. The shockwave spread out from the collapsing Atlantis, raging over the whole world, then seemed to bounce off the “edge” of the world and return, echoing again and again between heaven and earth.

In this violent impact and tearing far beyond human strength, the little paper boat let out unsettling ripping sounds. Even the mighty Sea Witch felt her control over the vessel racing toward its limit.

Shirley saw the grave look on Lucretia’s face at a glance. She hugged Dog’s head and let out a shrill scream: “Are we about to fall?!”

Lucretia frowned hard. She did not answer Shirley’s shout. Her gaze swept quickly over this already shattered world that was rushing toward

destruction. Then she suddenly raised her hand and pointed at the distant ground: “We will land over there.”

“Isn’t that just asking to die!” Shirley yelled. “Do you see any place left down there we can even stand on?!”

“corruption has stopped. Right now it is only fire burning everything. It is only fire. It is much friendlier than those strange, twisted Shadows.” Lucretia glanced at Shirley, did not care what Shirley thought, and had already begun forcing the tottering paper boat to dive toward a part of the forest where the flames were a little weaker.

The Origami Skiff, accompanied by Shirley’s broken screams, tore through the smoke in the forest and flew between two worlds that had become a living hell. The canopy of Atlantis collapsed above their heads. Burning giant trunks and leaves fell past the little boat like a crashing nightmare. Overhead, the upside-down land still kept sinking. By now Shirley could almost see the ravines in its ground and the rolling lines of its dunes.

Its fall was so slow it felt as if the process could last forever. Yet that fall was just as unstoppable, going on and on like a slowly grinding Doomsday that crushed everything in the mortal world inch by inch.

Lucretia steered the little boat with all her strength. Her gaze swept the forest again and again, trying to find a landing spot that was even a little “safer” in that inferno.

A blurred flash of light suddenly caught her eye.

In the next second the little boat sped toward that direction. It moved so fast Shirley almost thought they had gone into a runaway state and were simply falling. The boat shot through a Rain of Fire pouring down from the sky and through drifting sand that had somehow begun to fill the air, rolling like

ghosts between heaven and earth. It rushed straight toward the flash deep in the forest.

The flash slowly became clear.

It was a sheltering barrier of light, roughly cone-shaped, held up by a shimmering curtain.

Shirley saw the light as well. She leaned over the edge of the paper boat in surprise and stared down for a long time. At last she made out two familiar figures inside the barrier. “Ah! It’s Nina, and the old man!”

With Shirley’s delighted shout, the paper boat that carried her and Lucretia screamed through the last stretch of air. It finally reached its limit in the instant before it touched the ground. It broke apart in the impact and, in the blink of an eye, turned into fine dust.

Hugging Dog, Shirley jumped out at the last moment in a clumsy tumble. Girl and dog clutched each other as they rolled across the ground more than ten times before finally stopping in front of that cone of pale light.

She looked up and saw Nina standing inside the barrier, and beside her Morris, the old Mister, with a stunned look on his face.

A pile of spinning, colorful scraps of paper landed gently next to Shirley. Lucretia’s figure gathered out of the paper.

Nina waved to them from inside the barrier.

Shirley and Lucretia exchanged a glance, then stepped without hesitation into the layer of light that looked thin and fragile yet truly held back the tide of destruction raging through the forest.

In an instant, it felt as if the whole world went quiet.

The terrifying roar that had howled through the forest became barely audible. The scorching storm that had swept the land stayed outside the

light curtain. The choking smoke and the poisonous vapors boiling in the flames were also shut out. Shirley even felt a breath of fresh air rush toward her. She looked down and saw a few blades of grass under her feet and a small clump of shrubs beside them.

“Amazing…” She looked up in shock at Nina and Morris. “How did you make this? Lucretia and I could only run into the sky…”

“It wasn’t us.” Nina only shook her head gently. Then she turned a little to the side and raised her hand, pointing at a spot behind her and Morris.

Shirley looked over in surprise. The next second her eyes opened a little wider.

A small tree stood quietly there, rooted in this land that was breaking apart.

Its trunk was slender and weak. Its long branches climbed toward the sky, then drooped at the edge of the crown and swayed lightly in the breeze.

With this little tree at its center, the cone-shaped light curtain built the last safe Sanctuary World.

For a moment Shirley felt as if she heard a voice—

“Come with me. I will take you to the Wall of Silence…”

Then the voice faded into the wind.

“We are at the Wall of Silence now,” Nina said, turning her head to look into Shirley’s eyes. “The last, the true Wall of Silence.”

Shirley froze for a while, then slowly walked to the little tree. The drooping twigs at the edge of the crown brushed her shoulder and made her itch a bit.

She turned back and looked out beyond the thin curtain of light.

The world was falling apart. The mighty canopy of Atlantis bent, broke, and crashed under the “weight” of the other world. The forest burned. Far away,

the ground was lifted by an invisible force and slowly rolled upward toward the upside-down desert in the sky. The flames seemed to spread onto that desert as well. In the hazy distance, a faint layer of smoke appeared on the surface of “that world.”

Yet all those sounds seemed far away, as if they came from another world, like the soft waves outside a shut window at dusk.

“Yeah… it really is quiet.”

Even Shirley knew this silence probably would not last long.

But at least for this one second, that crumbling world was no longer chasing her, even if all that held it back was… a single pretty bubble.

What would happen next?

In the wind, Vanna narrowed her eyes a little.

She saw the upside-down world had already begun to touch the desert under her feet. The first thing to meet was the giant World Tree. Its crown now brushed the ground. That was where the giants had last vanished. Now it became the first “point of contact” between the two worlds. Then the distant mountains made contact. The mountains and rivers in the forest touched the range at the edge of the desert. There, flashing light burst without end, as if a world?tearing storm was brewing.

A sea of fire spread and flowed over her head. She saw the lush world above breaking apart in the flames. The desert under her feet was doing the same.

But the “collision” of the two worlds grew slower and slower, as if some power was forcing its progress to slow down and was interfering in this Doomsday.

Vanna lowered her head and looked at the brilliant sphere in her hand. Tiny flames flowed over the surface of the Sun. The light that burst from that fire had once shone on a glorious, radiant civilization before the age of the Deep Sea.

To this day, that sunlight still remained.

She raised her head again and looked at a place not far from her.

The huge Gatekeeper’s cane still stood planted in the dune. The sea of fire hanging from the sky lit up its rough shaft and head, which looked like trunk and stone. Firelight flowed over its rock?like surface. In that play of light and shadow she saw the countless words the giants had carved onto it.

For a moment Vanna felt as if she could read them. Line by line she ran her eyes over the dense words and symbols, as if she could still hear the giants’ deep, gentle voices speaking at her ear.

“Here, they learned to use fire.

“Here, they discovered the secret of farming.

“Here, there was a flood. The water covered the land, bringing death and fear, and later left rich soil behind…

“They learned to build ships…

“They learned to harness the power of thunder…”

Vanna slowly walked up to the Gatekeeper’s cane and looked up at the last blank patch near its end.

It was no longer blank.

At some unknown time, the giants had already carved the final line there. The God of Recorded History Ming had finished his last entry on the Chronicle Pillar:

“Tarrigan and the Traveler completed their final journey.”

Strange auras and unsettling rustling sounds came from far away. An unusual heat flowed through the air, gathering unseen.

Vanna turned and looked toward the direction she sensed.

She saw streams of light gathering. In the raging fire and twisted light cast by the two colliding worlds, chaotic flows of light slipped through some kind of “crack” and entered this place. Those streams grew hotter and hotter and gathered in the sky not far away, forming a fireball that grew larger and larger.

The fireball began to take on the shape of the Sun. Its edge trembled and sent out jets of flame. It began to float between the two worlds like the Sun, freely releasing disturbing pressure and waves of heat. Then it slowly lowered into the desert and slowly turned its true side toward Vanna.

Hidden inside the Sun’s shining shell were countless twisted tentacles piled together. Between the tentacles, eyes that were not human stared coldly at the Inquisitor standing by the dune.

“Kneel.”

This Sunspawn spoke.

Chapter 639

The invading “Sun” slowly came down. It could not compare to the real Sun, yet it was still as big as a hill and radiated terrifying power.

It hovered just above the ground, almost fully “landed” on the surface. Flames burst from its edge and licked the earth. Under its light the sand and stone melted into flowing magma. The air twisted in the heat. Over the spreading rivers of lava, waves of hot air rolled. Big and small rocks, disturbed by unseen power, floated around this Sunspawn and became blazing satellites that circled it.

This huge fallen Sun Wheel used its countless cold eyes inside to stare at the mortal in front of it, a being that could almost be called a speck of dust. It repeated that short, simple order—

“Kneel.”

Its pressure was completely different from that of any ordinary supernatural being or Heretic. It was power that spread from the Elder Gods. This deformed fireball was the true spawn of the Black Sun. Its words alone were equal to ten thousand spells and secret rites.

Vanna felt as if her body was about to burn. Scorching fire seemed to flow through her. Even the breath she exhaled became part of the flames.

But she only lowered her head and glanced quietly at the small, dazzling sphere in her hand.

A moment later she tucked it carefully close against her body. Then, still silent, she turned and walked to the huge Gatekeeper's cane that was buried deep in the dune. She reached out her left hand and slowly pulled it up with steady force, then lifted it onto her shoulder.

For a mortal, the giants' Gatekeeper's cane was far too huge. Even for Vanna, when she carried the Cane it did not look like she held a weapon. It looked more like she was carrying a great tree.

But she did not care. This heavy "weapon" was just right for her.

She turned around. In her right hand she gripped the greatsword of solid ice. Her left hand held the Cane resting on her shoulder. She calmly stared at the "Sun" that had fallen on the ground.

"You refused," the Sunspawn hissed and trembled, letting out a string of harsh sounds. Its will stabbed straight into Vanna's mind. "But you must hand over that star."

The wind in the desert grew stronger and stronger. Gust after endless gust tore through the last gap between the two worlds, as if it meant to lift the whole desert into the air. In the distance, sand rose into the storm and turned into a towering yellow wall that slowly moved toward this place.

In the howling wind, Vanna raised her head and glanced at the other world, now hanging still above the sky. She asked calmly: "Are you the one interfering with this… 'collision'?"

"You are trying to call on power from afar, but no one can help you," the fallen Sun hissed again, its noise full of tremors. "I have cut off the link between the two worlds. Now you are trapped in this desert. No one can hear your voice. Not the bearer of the Flame Usurper. Not the Leviathan Queen. Resistance is useless… Hand it over, and I can let you go."

Vanna did not answer this spawn of the Elder Gods. She only narrowed her eyes a little as the wind grew more violent.

It was true she could not reach the outside. She could not reach the captain, nor the Storm Goddess. Gentle waves still sounded at her ears, and the fire of spirit form still burned in her body where its mark remained. But she could no longer hear their “source.”

The force of the worlds’ collision had become a shield of mental guidance that blocked everything, turning this desert into a sealed prison. And the one driving all of this was clearly this… blasphemy before her.

The wind began to gather. The far?off yellow wall of sand, lifted by the storm, rolled forward bit by bit under the push of the wind. It was an astonishing storm. In its growing power, countless grains of sand surged and roared inside that wall like a gigantic wave.

Vanna drew a light breath. Ash?like matter drifted into the air with her breath.

She gazed at the Sunspawn on the distant ground. Storm and fire danced in her eyes.

She lowered the huge Gatekeeper’s cane from her shoulder. Then she started forward, her eyes calm, walking toward that profaned Sun. The Cane and the greatsword dragged across the ground and carved two long furrows, which for a moment looked like a line of symbols carved into the earth.

If a giant had been here, he might really have carved such a line—

After Doomsday, the Traveler charged the invading Sun.

But the giants were gone. The history of this world had already ended. The storm wiped away the long furrows behind Vanna, and the soaring sand closed behind her like a giant curtain.

Her steps grew faster, turning into a full charge.

Would the Sunspawn feel surprise? Perhaps in all its knowledge there had never been an option called “a mortal charges a spawn of the Elder Gods.” But could a creature like it feel anything like a human?

Vanna was very curious about that. Yet she had no way to know the answer. She only knew that proud “Sun” finally reacted.

Layer upon layer of heat waves crossed the Sun’s surface, forming a honeycomb?like coat of blazing light. Flames brewed and rose in the air. deadly sunlight burned her body and tried to kill her before she could reach it.

But the sandstorm rolling in from the far end of the desert was closing around her, forming a shield that could, for a time, block that sunlight.

Vanna ran forward with all her strength. As she ran she slowly raised the greatsword and the long staff in her hands. She breathed in the burning heat. With every breath, ash drifted into the air.

She felt as if she was cutting through waves.

A voice seemed to speak in her heart. She no longer knew whether it was her own voice, or the Storm Goddess’, or the captain’s. She only knew that this voice told her—

The sea of sand was also a sea.

She would raise a storm on this sea.

Because she was the Saint of the Storm.

In the roaring wind, the yellow wall of sand closed. Vanna’s figure vanished into the vast sandstorm, as if swallowed in an instant, or as if it had merged with the storm itself.

Between the two colliding lands, only a single desert storm remained, almost joining the two worlds. It rose a thousand meters high and roared forward with enough sound to shake the earth.

Inside the great storm, a pointed wedge rose high. After a one?second pause, it came crashing down like a falling sky toward the invading Sunspawn.

Today, she would try to put out a Sun.

An impact that seemed enough to tear the earth apart burst out in an instant.

The huge storm that spanned the desert shrank into a single wedge and struck the Sun head on. At the instant before impact, the Sun threw up a glorious corona. The corona exploded under the blow, and a wave of destructive matter burst out.

It was as if the whole desert caught fire in that blast. In a single instant, the terrible wave of flame flattened every nearby dune and boulder. The jagged rocks melted and ran like water, filling the furrows and pits in the ground.

In the great explosion of the “corona,” the storm was also torn apart and scattered. The roaring wind suddenly turned into chaotic air currents and rushed out in all directions between heaven and earth. The yellow sand that had formed walls and wedges was ripped into pieces in the heat. Part of it fell back to the ground. Part of it seemed to lose its weight and was flung into the gap between the two worlds, where it gathered around the upside? down Atlantis like clouds.

No one knew how long it took before the wild wind finally blew the sand away from the center of the impact.

A beam of light appeared first in the thinning dust.

The Sunspawn still existed. Its light had dimmed. The hastily raised “False Sun” corona had blocked the force of the storm during the impact, but it had

also torn away part of its body. Now its tentacles, curled up inside the shell of fire, twisted and shook in pain. Something gold and red, like flowing flame and like blood, seeped from its burning shell and floated on the molten lake around it, burning as it flowed.

Countless inhuman eyes rolled between those spasming tentacles, searching for the enemy's figure after the sand had cleared.

That figure stood at the edge of a fan?shaped impact crater not far away.

Vanna stood there quietly. The air around her twisted with heat. The last faint wind faded from the tip of her sword.

She lifted her head and glanced at the distant Sunspawn.

In the next second, her body blew apart in the wind. She turned into countless drifting ashes that floated down over the earth in the sunlight.

A small sphere of dazzling light dropped out of the air and landed on the still?hot ashes.

"…In the end, still a mortal, but worthy of respect."

The Sunspawn let out a muffled tremor and slowly floated higher. It called on unseen power and reached out to take the "Ancient Star" that had fallen into the pile of ash.

The star did not move at all.

"…Hm?"

For the first time, this spawn of the Elder Gods felt a trace of confusion.

The next second, a sudden gust of wind swept across the sand and lifted the ashes scattered on the ground.

A ghostly green light slowly appeared in the ash, then in almost the blink of an eye burned into a fierce blaze. Some nameless, chaotic shadow swept

over the ashes and, as if rebuilding a soul, shaped a faint, human?like form. Then all the ashes, pulled by that eerie green flame, floated into the air and quickly gathered, reshaping themselves and regaining color and weight. In only a few seconds, they formed Vanna’s body once more.

Even her broken armor was restored as the ghostly green flame passed over it, as if time itself had flowed backward.

Vanna bent down, casually picked up her sword and the Gatekeeper’s cane, then raised her head and looked at the false Sun that still burned fiercely.

She saw its twitching tentacles and the gold?red stuff spilling from its shell of fire.

A smile slowly appeared at the corner of her mouth.

“So you can bleed too.”

She started walking toward it.

Once more, wild wind swept across the world. Sand rose again in the storm.

“Then the next question—can you feel fear?”

Chapter 640:

A roar louder than thunder and more terrifying than a collapsing mountain echoed between the two worlds. It shook again and again between the two inverted lands, even driving away the sea of fire and smoke around Atlantis. It pierced the calm brought by the Wall of Silence and startled Lucretia and the others from their short rest.

Shirley almost jumped up from the ground at once. She lifted her head toward the source of the roar and shouted: “What just blew up?! What was that?!”

Nina ran to the edge of the Protective Ward. She craned her neck to stare at the upside-down desert continent in the sky and pointed: “Look up there! There was a huge explosion over there!”

Shirley looked toward where Nina was pointing, and her eyes slowly widened.

On that upside-down land, she saw a raging storm. Faint storm clouds swept over the ground like a moving wall. Inside the storm, she could see large bursts of light. Every time a light burst flared, the storm itself seemed to be driven back for a moment, and a terrifying roar echoed between the two worlds. Then the storm rebuilt itself and once more gathered toward a bright region of flame.

With each blast and explosion, pieces of the “other world” were thrown out into the space between the two worlds. Countless sand and dust now floated over Atlantis. They drifted without order in the gap between the two worlds

as if there were no gravity, forming rivers of flowing sand hanging in the sky, and clouds of dust of all sizes.

The slow collision of the two worlds had already stopped at some point, as if some outside force had jammed the process. Only the constant roaring was left between heaven and earth. The material that kept being thrown out between the two lands gathered into larger and larger clouds.

“We cannot stay here any longer,” Morris said suddenly. “Something may have happened to Vanna. We have not been able to reach her since just now.”

“So we are going over there?” Shirley raised her hand and pointed to the other world hanging above their heads. “I do not mind, but how do we get there? The paper boat Lucretia folded before turned to ash when we ‘landed’…”

Before she finished, Lucretia had already pulled out a sheet of white paper from who knew where and waved it in front of everyone: “I still have paper. I will fold another one.”

Shirley stared blankly at the witch as she took out the white paper, her expression a bit odd: “We are still… folding it out of paper? We do not have anything sturdier?”

Lucretia thought for a moment, then took out another sheet from inside her coat.

“I will stack two sheets together.”

Shirley clearly still felt this was not very reliable, but she could not beat anyone here, so she wisely and carefully kept her opinion to herself. While she and Dog watched with great caution, Lucretia threw a new paper boat out beyond the barrier.

The paper boat grew and stretched quickly in midair. In the blink of an eye it became a small white boat, floating outside the translucent curtain of light like a light, drifting cloud.

Nina stared, dumbfounded, then could not help letting out a cry of amazement: “That is amazing! How did you do that?! Can I learn it?”

“Just a witch’s trick. I suggest you do not get too interested,” Lucretia glanced at Nina’s face full of envy, waved her hand, and walked toward the barrier. “At your stage, it is more useful to learn math, physics, and chemistry first…”

Nina pressed her lips together with a strange look, then lifted her head to look at the ruined world beyond the barrier.

She took a light breath, then turned back to look at the small tree that was holding up the last Wall of Silence.

Two seconds later, she and Shirley both raised their hands at the little tree at the same time and softly said goodbye.

A moment later, the Origami Skiff rose silently into the sky. It carried them away from the scorched earth and flew toward the upside-down world at the end of the sky.

Shirley lay on the edge of the boat, leaning out to look down at the forest that was slowly being covered by darkness and smoke. She watched the small cone-shaped curtain of light sink into the thick smoke and vanish after a few flashes. Only after a long time did she finally mutter in a low voice: “Are we ever going to see that tree again?”

“No. Everything here will eventually fade away, and that is the best result for the Mortal Realm,” Lucretia’s voice came from beside her, calm and almost inhumanly cool and rational. “This place is only a part of the elves’

racial memory. Everything here already died in a very distant past. Atlantis, Celine, Saslokar… they all died a very, very long time ago."

"I know, I know," Shirley waved her hand, a little annoyed, and her tone held a complaint. "You do not have to say it that clearly. I was just feeling a little emotional…"

Lucretia ignored Shirley's grumbling. She focused on steering the little paper boat, and soon shifted her attention from the forest below to the distant World Tree.

Even though the slow collision of the two worlds had paused for now, the collapse of Atlantis still went on. The huge canopy that had once covered the sky had been completely burned through by the sea of fire flowing across the heavens, becoming a terrible tangle of charred remains in the flames. Embers still flowed along the branches that wound like mountain ranges, and some of the fire had even spread to the "other world".

But those flames that spread over seemed to be blocked by something. They could only float above the desert and could not truly touch that world.

Thunderous sounds rolled from the direction of Atlantis as the great collapse of the World Tree neared its peak.

The canopy, burned by fire, began to break off in whole sheets, falling to the ground like great cities dropping from the clouds. Mountains tore apart under the tree's collapse. Gorges and ravines slowly filled and were covered by the tree's ashes. Smoke and dust blotted out the sky. Atlantis was slowly turning into the sight Nina and Morris had first seen.

The little boat slowly approached the boundary between the two worlds.

"Everyone be careful. We may have a Gravity Inversion in a moment," Morris called out. "Do not panic. Hold on to the rail."

Nina and Shirley reacted at once. They were very obedient and grabbed the edge of the paper boat. Dog dug his claws tightly into the raised folds in the floor of the boat.

Lucretia made ready for the Gravity Inversion while carefully guiding the boat higher.

But just when she was ready for everything, a huge sense of danger suddenly surged up from her heart.

An attack.

That thought had barely formed when Lucretia jerked the boat to the side. But she was still a step too late. In the next second, a streak of light suddenly appeared in the air and slashed past. Even though it only grazed the side, the edge of the paper boat was instantly torn and set on fire.

The next moment, endless light appeared before everyone's eyes.

It was a web of rays, a hidden barrier in the gap between the two worlds. It only showed itself when uninvited guests tried to approach the desert world. The interwoven light was bright and pure, shining like sunlight, yet it carried burning malice and a twisted, mad, terrifying aura.

The vast curtain of light surged in the sky. Streams of flame rose from its edge like a rainstorm falling from the heavens, pouring down over the shaking little paper boat.

In that "rain" of fire and glare, Shirley and Dog shouted in unison: "What is this thing?!"

"It is the power of the Creeping Sun Wheel…" Lucretia had already recognized the familiar, blasphemous aura in that rolling light. She hurried to force the boat downward and spoke quickly. "I knew it… The Sunspawn slipped in. That thing has sealed the sky!"

Before she finished, a dazzling flash suddenly cut across everyone’s vision.

The flash almost tore the entire paper boat apart.

The shredded boat lost control and started to wobble and fall toward the ground.

Shirley wrapped her arms around Dog’s neck at once and yelled at the top of her lungs: “I cannot fly!”

Her shout echoed in the sky, but at that moment a strange sound of some giant thing tearing and rumbling suddenly came from far away, cutting her voice off.

The strange sound was so intense that it felt as if the whole world went quiet.

In the shaking, falling paper boat, Lucretia opened her eyes wide and looked toward the source of the sound in surprise.

It was the trunk of Atlantis’s World Tree.

Somewhere near the base of the trunk, a ripping roar was bursting out.

The ground trembled. Cracks big enough to be seen from this distance spread across the trunk that loomed like a giant mountain. In the next second, the cracks widened, and a blazing ghostly green flame burst out from within.

In the rapidly spreading spirit form flames, a huge shadow pushed out from Atlantis’s trunk. First came a proud prow, then tall masts and half-transparent spirit-form sails, then a wide deck, neat rows of gunports, and a towering stern…

It was the Vanished, now fully transformed into its spirit form. It had torn through the remains of Atlantis and entered this world near the roots of the World Tree.

Then it began to rise. It flew over the scorched ground, over the forest where the fires still smoldered, sailed across this broken, ruined world, and headed steadily higher.

The ghost ship sailed in the sky under the afterglow of Doomsday.

Its unreal spirit form flames rolled behind it like foam and wake on the ocean, spreading out in layers. They washed over the sea of fire surrounding Atlantis, as if trying to set the whole world alight once more.

Chapter 641:

Through the last thin link she still had with the paper boat, Lucretia did her best to steer it toward the Vanished as it flew over the forest.

The Vanished also noticed the little boat swaying in the air and about to crash. It suddenly sped up. In its spirit form state, the huge hull moved as lightly as a gust of wind and, in almost an instant, it reached the space beneath Lucretia and the others.

The torn paper boat hit the deck like a cloud in a runaway state after several dangerous shifts in direction, finally crashing down in a crooked line.

Shirley and Dog tumbled out of the boat, rolled across the deck several times, and only then managed to stop. A tall figure appeared in front of them. Duncan bent down, grabbed the dizzy Shirley, and hauled her to her feet, then reached out and caught Nina as she rolled over as well.

Shirley still seemed dazed. After she stood up, she shook her head hard. Only then did her eyes slowly focus again. She looked around and finally relaxed fully: “We are actually still alive… I thought I was dead for sure this time…”

“Uncle Duncan!” Nina cheered happily and threw herself into Duncan’s arms.

Duncan smiled, patted Nina’s hair, hugged her lightly, then looked up into the distance.

Morris stood steady on the deck. One hand rested on the Gatekeeper's cane, and in his other hand he held a delicate mechanical device that looked like a gyroscope. He watched them with a slight smile. Lucretia drifted down lightly from a nearby mast. When the paper boat was about to hit the deck, she had left it a moment early.

Then she had gotten caught on the mast.

"Looks like you are all in pretty good shape," Duncan said with a smile and gave them a nod. "But honestly, flying toward a burning sky in an Origami Skiff is a bit risky."

Lucretia, who was walking over, showed an awkward look at once: "This spell definitely has room for improvement…"

Nina quickly tugged on Duncan's arm and pointed up at the glowing curtain that seemed to divide the two worlds: "Uncle, look up there…"

Duncan nodded lightly: "I have already seen it."

A brilliant curtain of light, as if cast from pure sunlight, covered the sky between the two worlds, hanging like a low shell over the desert continent of yellow sand.

The Vanished kept rising. It had now reached the highest point above the forest. The shining sunlight barrier almost brushed the tip of the ship's tallest mast. Faint ripples spread out from that mast tip over the barrier, looking gentle and harmless.

"Vanna may be trapped on the other side," Morris said as he walked over, his face grave. "This barrier is made from the power of the Creeping Sun Wheel. Whoever built it is aiming at that 'Sun' Vanna told us about. We just crashed into this barrier a moment ago."

Duncan nodded: "I know. This barrier is trying to keep me out."

“So what do we do now?” Nina raised her head curiously. “Can we just smash our way in?”

Duncan gave her a helpless look: “You have been led astray by Shirley. A girl should not have her head full of smashing into things. Do not always think of such rough methods.”

As he spoke, he lifted his head to look at the vast, majestic sunlight Veil floating above the Vanished.

The next second, a light creaking came from deep inside the ship. Then the ghost ship, burning with fierce spirit flame, suddenly lifted higher and charged straight toward the rolling sea of light.

Gravity Inversion happened. At the instant the flip came, the Vanished rolled hard within the curtain of light to adjust to the change in gravity after crossing the boundary between the two worlds.

When Shirley once again dragged herself up from the deck in a daze, she saw that the Vanished was sailing on the surface of the hot, heaving curtain of light. Under the light lay the hazy desert land. Above her head, hanging upside down, were the familiar forest and the wrecked Atlantis.

The sunlight Veil that separated the two worlds reacted almost at once, just as it had when the paper boat drew near earlier. The blazing sunlight turned into surging flames in the blink of an eye and poured in wave after wave toward the uninvited ship sailing on its surface. The flames rose like mountains, roaring and boiling as they rushed in.

But every tongue of light and flame that neared the Vanished was tinted with a soft green almost at once, turning into gentle spirit flame that circled the ship.

In the next second, these ghost-green flames began to spread over the barrier like growing corruption, covering more and more of it and moving

faster and faster.

The barrier that had seemed so grand and splendid was being burned through and melted at a speed visible to the naked eye.

Nina's eyes went wide as she watched the golden curtain beyond the rail turn into a sea of spreading green flame in almost an instant. She let out a soft sound of awe: "Ooh…"

Duncan did not speak. He simply let his gaze rest on the "borderline" between the two worlds, and a thoughtful look slowly appeared on his face.

He was still recalling what he had seen in that moment when the Gravity Inversion happened.

The direction of gravity had changed in an instant. There was no "balance point" of zero gravity between the two worlds. As he approached the border, he had not felt gravity weaken bit by bit and then change direction. There was no gradual process.

This showed even more clearly that the "collision" of the two worlds was not a simple physical process, not just two celestial bodies touching each other on a physical level. They were already this close, yet the gravity of the two lands still stayed completely separate and independent, as if they were…

Incompatible.

At the same time that this "incompatible" state appeared, strange corruption had shown up in both the forest world and the desert world. Everything twisted. Unnamable things grew out of the shadows. Atlantis had started to collapse and burn on its own even before the upside-down desert drew near. It all felt like…

A kind of mental corruption on the level of entire worlds.

Two worlds that could not read each other, could not make sense of each other, and could not be made to fit together were twisting at the same time as they drew close.

Duncan lifted his head and looked at Atlantis, now hanging upside down in the sky and falling apart in the flames. The World Tree there was already unrecognizable. In its collapse, the elves' home world was slowly showing a state of complete corruption, dissolving and breaking apart in chaos and dark.

The elves' unique racial nature had shaped this strange dimension called the Nameless One's Dream. Atlantis was trapped here in an eternal nightmare, and what he saw now was the deepest part of that nightmare.

This moment was before the Deep Sea era opened. The Great Annihilation was happening.

The true nature of the Great Annihilation… was the collision of two worlds.

Duncan suddenly frowned.

Two worlds? Was it really only two worlds?

He suddenly thought of the "warrior" who had turned into living metal, and of the world of swords and magic that had crumbled at dusk. He thought of the Moon over his home, of the endless mist outside his apartment door, of the many conflicting records still kept in the city-states, of the countless strange legends written in the books of the Age of Darkness, of those ancient civilizations that could never be proved real, of those relics that did not belong to any known civilization, and of the strong corruption carried by those relics.

Some relics were like poison to this world just by existing. Simply placing them somewhere would twist and corrupt everything around them.

And there were other things that were not even allowed to appear in the Mortal Realm. There was no way to contain or make them harmless. Destroying them at once was the only safe way to deal with them. People spoke of them in fear and called them… “Blasphemous Archetypes”.

Duncan stood quietly on the deck of the Vanished, in the narrow gap between two worlds that were destroying each other. Faced with Universal Extinction and Doomsday, he finally saw the truth of the Great Annihilation.

Lucretia suddenly felt something.

It was as if an invisible wind was stirring over the deck, and a heavy, suffocating pressure was forming at her side.

She turned quickly toward the source of that weight.

A blaze of starlight stood quietly not far from her. The starlight outlined a hazy human shape. It seemed to stand right in front of her, yet at the same time it felt as if it stood at an infinite distance. It did not look very tall, but it gave a sense of endless size, as if she could never truly see its edges.

Lucretia remembered that she had seen this starlight before. It had been not long ago, when she met her Father again for the first time. In one dangerous instant, in a fleeting glimpse, she had seen a bit of the “truth” behind Father’s shell.

But this time was different.

All the rules of light and her normal sight seemed to fail before that starlight. Lucretia was shocked to find her vision bending inside it. Strange “rules” she could not understand were forming within the light. She tried to look away, but found she could not.

Her gaze seemed to have become part of the starlight.

Then, in the next second, just when she thought her mind would be completely swallowed and made one with that giant starlight, all the light faded.

A broad hand covered her eyes.

Lucretia froze for a moment before she realized what it was. It was Father's hand.

She grabbed the hand in a daze, gently pushed it away, and looked toward the place where the blazing starlight had been.

The starlight had crumpled back into Duncan's form.

"Do not be afraid," she heard Father say to her softly. "I am still here."

"What just happened?" Lucretia blinked. Only after she heard Duncan's voice did she finally relax. But the "burn" left by that starlight still felt deeply branded in her mind. "Just now, you…"

"Nothing," Duncan said in a low voice. "I just suddenly understood some things."

Chapter 642:

For Duncan, the “Great Annihilation” was no longer a completely unknown mystery. In the endless, heavy depth of the ancient Veil, the truth finally lifted a corner of its shroud for him—one crucial corner.

It was the collision between worlds that caused the Great Annihilation. The “incompatibility” between those worlds twisted the ruins after the impact into the strange and dangerous age of the Deep Sea. The scene buried in the deepest layer of Atlantis’s nightmare was only a small image taken from that collision.

And it was only a small image—those two worlds were far from the only ones that crashed together.

Duncan could feel that as he “understood” more of this truth, some kind of change was taking place, and that change was happening inside him.

For a brief instant just now, he even felt that everything in front of him turned into chaotic, empty… colors. In those colors he saw the true nature of the world. He saw that everything was like stars on the verge of falling. Each tiny light was made from abstract descriptions of information.

He also saw that all things stayed at the edge of a slow collapse. Their conflicting natures made them keep breaking apart and recombining in the depths of information. He seemed to understand the world’s real face, and he almost found the “single solution” to all contradictions and all imbalance.

But it lasted for only an instant.

He still seemed to lack something, a single, most important “parameter”.

Duncan’s reason returned to the Mortal Realm. He blinked. It felt as if countless voices were roaring inside his skull. Then the roaring slowly faded, and his thoughts began to clear.

He had already understood the nature of the Great Annihilation, and he understood how the Deep Sea age had formed… but what was that missing “key parameter”? He already understood the truth of the world, so what was left that he still did not understand?

The strong impression from that glimpse of the world’s true side still lingered in his mind. He could not help thinking about those abstract, difficult questions. But soon, he forced his thoughts to stop and noticed the worried look Lucretia was giving him.

Now was not the time to keep thinking about those things.

“It’s nothing. I just suddenly understood a few things.” He waved his hand, then turned his head and looked past the ship’s rail.

The Vanished was sailing along the surface of a curtain of light made from false sunlight. Blazing spirit form flames were spreading quickly over that curtain. They corroded and burned through this seemingly powerful barrier, and the clash of forces raised waves of storms made from light and fire in the distance.

But it still looked like it would take some time to completely melt through this “wall of light”.

Unless… a “weak point” appeared inside the barrier itself…

Beneath the light curtain and the sea of fire, on that nameless world covered in yellow sand, a desert storm formed once more. In the heart of the storm, a huge flash erupted again.

The howling wind that swept across the entire desert scattered once more. In the wild, chaotic currents of air, the Veil formed by the storm split into shreds, and the sand and dust fell back down in a dense rain.

In the fading haze of dust, a “sun” whose light was growing dim slowly appeared again. It floated above a lake of rolling lava, its surface flickering and swelling in a way that could be seen with the naked eye.

A breeze rose. Ash gathered and slowly reshaped.

“What are you?!”

The chaotic, trembling roar finally rang out again. A language humans could not understand mixed with that horrible noise. Under the false solar shell, the countless eyes of the Sunspawn trembled violently and stared hard at the figure walking out of the ash.

Emotion finally appeared in its roar, something almost like a human’s… rage.

Vanna slowly raised her greatsword. Her gaze stayed calm as she looked at the “sun” that had fallen to the ground in front of her and said slowly: “In the end you’re only an offshoot of the elder gods. You’re not that strong.”

But the Sunspawn ignored her. It only kept repeating: “What are you?!”

Vanna finally lowered her head and looked at her own body.

The last wisp of ash was being drawn back into her by the pull of the spirit form flames. She could feel her senses waking from numbness. Blood reappeared and began to flow again. A heart—a heart like a human’s—had already begun to beat once more in her chest.

She could even feel the process of that heart being reshaped.

“Just a pile of ash.” She stepped forward as she answered in a soft voice.

“Ash? No… you are not ash at all!” The Sunspawn’s hoarse, deep tremor came from far away. “Subspace… You carry the breath of Subspace. You are a Subspace shadow that leaked into the Mortal Realm—what are you?!”

Vanna suddenly stopped.

A trace of shock appeared in her eyes, followed by thought. Then she seemed to faintly understand something and spoke in a thoughtful tone: “You’re saying I am a Subspace shadow?”

The Sunspawn did not answer her question. It only let out a low, uneasy, jumbled noise. Its fire and light drew together again, repairing and reshaping the “corona” on its surface.

Vanna did not care. She had never expected to hear a complete answer from this blasphemous thing. Or rather, she had already gotten her answer.

Yes. By definition, she was the one who counted as a Subspace shadow. It was the power of Subspace that reshaped that pile of ash from more than ten years ago into “Vanna”. In that reshaping, she had already become a creation of Subspace in essence.

So a “being that returned from Subspace” should look like her.

“So… the captain is another kind of being…”

Vanna murmured softly to herself. Then she seemed to sense something. She lifted her head and quietly fixed her gaze on the “sun” lying on the distant land.

The Sunspawn felt her gaze. It also felt something deeply uneasy inside that gaze. Its surface swelled and writhed. It began to let out a low tremor, as if it were threatening her, or warning her.

But Vanna only laughed. She did not care at all about the waves of heat rising again around her, or about the deadly “sunlight” gathering slowly on

the Sunspawn’s body.

“So you can feel fear too.” She let out a small breath and spoke with a smile.

Then the sky caught fire.

A sea of fire, rolling like an ocean and boiling like a storm, appeared all at once. In almost the blink of an eye, it covered a third of the sky. The flames briefly scattered the clouds and fog between the two worlds, then began to sink and curve downward toward the land.

A huge shadow appeared at the center of that sea of fire. It pressed down slowly as if it meant to pierce the sky itself. At the same time, layers of pale golden sunlight flashed for a moment along the edge of the fire. They seemed to be trying to rebuild the barrier and block this “invasion”. But in the next second, that sunlight shattered like glass. With the sound of something breaking, huge ship-timbers wrapped in flame finally fell from the sky.

The Sunspawn let out a wild chain of roars. It was shocked to find that the barrier it had built so carefully had already been melted through by some outside force, and even the flames on the barrier no longer obeyed its will. Then its many eyes were drawn to the giant ship descending from the heavens.

The “shell” made from fire and light opened. The tentacles piled up inside stretched and uncurled in the sunlight against their own will. Eye after eye that did not look like a human’s turned toward the outline of the Vanished. They stared at that mass of fire, at the figure standing inside that fire.

Truth had come.

A voice came from the sky: “You see me now.”

At once, the flames covering the Sunspawn’s shell turned a ghostly green. The green fire spread over the body of this child of the elder gods like a living thing. In a blink, it set the creature ablaze from the inside out, transforming it.

But it was not burned to ash in an instant. While the roaring spirit form flames burned through it, it actually struggled free of the ground and suddenly shot up toward the sky.

Almost at the same time, a bright stream of flame erupted from the bow of the Vanished.

It was a golden arc of fire. The stream of flame burst from the ghost ship’s bow as if from an eruption and rushed straight into the sky. It did not hesitate as it flew toward the Sunspawn, which was dragging a long tail of fire like an upside?falling star, and pierced it in a single instant.

Yet that “fireball” still did not die. It only paused for a moment, then struggled and continued to fly upward.

It was almost about to escape from this world.

But just as the fireball was about to become a fading blur at the edge of the sky, a huge phantom suddenly appeared in its path.

It was a black billy goat.

He was as large as a mountain and drifted at the horizon like a dark cloud. Phantom lightning jumped between His horns, while ghostly green firelight glowed in His eyes. His body gathered and formed out of the sea of spirit form fire flowing through the sky, and His outline stayed hazy and shifting. He dipped His head a little toward the Vanished in a silent greeting, then turned His eyes toward the fireball that was trying to flee.

The billy goat stepped back a few paces among the clouds. Then He lowered His head and suddenly sped up. The sea of fire gathered behind

Him, then spread under His hooves to form a road. He began to run along this flaming path, like a black shooting star falling from the clouds. In a blink, He moved faster than the eye could follow, then slammed hard into the fireball that was rising faster and faster into the sky.

The huge explosion and impact shattered the last clouds between the two worlds. It even shattered the distant mountains and part of the already crumbling land. In the crash, the rising fireball broke into countless pieces. Large and small fragments turned to dust at once in the burning of the ghostly green flame. One shining “core” fell from the sky, but only halfway down it was swallowed by a burst of spirit form fire that appeared out of thin air and vanished in an instant.

The Black Goat walked out of the fiery storm born from the great explosion. He stepped down from the edge of the clouds toward the ground and, together with the Vanished, landed in front of Vanna.

Chapter 643:

The shockwaves from the great explosion rippled back and forth between the two worlds. The chaotic winds they stirred up whipped Vanna's silver hair. She raised a hand to shield her eyes from wind and sand. She watched the ghost ship wrapped in roaring flames slowly descend toward the sea of sand, then saw the huge Black Goat step down from the clouds and walk, step by step, to stand beside the Vanished.

Then a stream of flame fell from the deck of the Vanished like a meteor. It burst open before her eyes, widening into a great door. Duncan stepped out from the door.

"Captain!" Vanna snapped back to herself at once. She started toward Duncan, but after only half a step her body swayed and she nearly pitched forward onto the ground. In the last second before she fell, she planted the Gatekeeper's cane left by the giants and leaned on it. She wobbled twice and finally steadied herself.

Duncan hurried up to her: "How are you?"

Vanna held the Gatekeeper's cane with one hand and raised her head with some effort. She forced a small smile. "This time I really… pushed myself."

Then she dismissed the longsword in her other hand with a casual gesture. She reached into her clothes and groped around before taking out the "sun" that was still giving off warm, dazzling light. Her hand shook a little as she held it out to Duncan: "Here. This is the 'sun' Tarrigan left behind… it's completely intact."

Duncan noticed the name at once: “Tarrigan?”

“Yes. That giant… His name was Tarrigan.” Vanna nodded lightly. “He was the God of Recorded History. Long, long ago, He fell on the day the Great Annihilation took place.”

Duncan frowned hard and stared at the ancient “star” in Vanna’s hand, which shone with a warm light. Countless thoughts rose and fell in his mind before he finally reached out and took the sphere.

Warmth spread from his palm. The slow-turning flames on the surface of the sphere gently licked at his hand—but right now there was something even more important.

Duncan slipped the “sun” into his coat. He stepped forward to support Vanna’s arm, then used his other hand to take the huge Gatekeeper’s cane from her, rough and thick as a tree trunk. He could clearly see that this brave maiden was close to her limit.

Vanna did not try to act strong. She let out a breath and leaned most of her weight on the captain. At the same time, she lifted her head to glance at the huge Black Goat still standing quietly beside the Vanished and asked in a thoughtful tone: “…Is that the First Mate?”

“How did you recognize him?”

“The face. Even blown up this big, you can still tell.” Vanna spoke as she walked, then could not help adding, “Besides, I do use my brain sometimes.”

“It really is him. I repaired the keel of the Vanished and shared part of my own fire with him, so he could return to this form for a short time,” Duncan said as he led Vanna toward the flaming gate still standing at the edge of the dune. “We can talk about the details later. For now we go back to the ship. This is not over yet.”

As if to prove his words, even before Duncan finished speaking, a low, strange rumble and an unsettling howl began to roll in from far away. It sounded like two huge millstones starting to grind against each other again. Terrifying vibrations and thunderous booms echoed through both worlds at the same time.

On the far horizon, the “collision” that had paused before started again. Mountains collapsed. Clouds began to boil. In the sky above, in the ruins of Atlantis, a huge firelight appeared once more. Forests and land that darkness had almost swallowed completely were being rebuilt, as if time itself were running backward. But in the process of rebuilding, they took on twisted and frightening forms. In the very next second, those forests and lands, newly reborn and twisted, broke apart again and were swallowed by darkness. The process repeated over and over, step by step slipping into madness.

Around Vanna, terrible winds rose once more in the endless desert. This time, however, she was not the one controlling the “storm”. It felt as if countless grim phantoms were hidden in the gale, roaring and howling. Each phantom called out the names of the dead. A towering wall of sandstorm formed in the wind. Inside that wall, the shadows of cities and mountain ranges faintly appeared.

The final collision and fusion of the two worlds had begun.

In the last second before the storm hit, Duncan pulled Vanna through the spinning gate of flame.

The next second, she was already standing on the deck of the Vanished. The blazing spirit form flames outside the ghost ship formed a wall. The awful scene of the worlds colliding turned into warped, hazy images beyond the fire. Yet even through that fiery barrier, she seemed to hear both worlds screaming at once and the terrible roar of all things coming apart.

“I thought it was over…” She stared in shock at the world tearing itself apart beyond the rail. She felt the tremors running through the deck grow stronger and stronger and could not react for a moment. “Why…”

“We only destroyed the Sunspawn that invaded the dream of the Nameless One. Atlantis’s nightmare will not end because of that,” Duncan’s voice sounded beside her. “This is the deepest layer of the elves’ racial memory. A scene from the Great Annihilation was carved into it. The collision and extinction of two worlds is the ending this nightmare is bound to reach.”

The shaking of the whole ship grew stronger. Vanna braced herself, trying hard to keep her balance. She stared wide?eyed at the sight of all things collapsing in the distance and finally could not hold back: “Then how do we stop all this…”

Duncan only turned his head and quietly met her eyes. “Stop it? Stop what? Stop the collision of two worlds? Or stop the Great Annihilation from happening?”

Vanna froze, as if she were slowly catching on.

“The Great Annihilation already happened. In real history, as the beginning of the Deep Sea age, it has long since happened and ended. What remains here is only a ‘memory’ of something that already took place. We cannot stop it and have no need to stop it,” Duncan said, shaking his head slowly. “What we must stop is Atlantis.”

Vanna fell silent and only showed a thoughtful look.

Duncan walked slowly to the edge of the deck. He looked into the distance, at the doomsday scene of the world being erased.

The fusion of the two worlds had begun. At the end of the “collision”, the two inverted lands did not truly overlap in a physical sense. Before they

could, they fell apart. In round after round of reshaping and twisted disintegration, they slowly turned into some dark and chaotic… “thing”.

Above and below the Vanished, around the deck, beyond the ship’s rail, the forests, mountains, deserts, and rivers of the past were all torn open. They soon lost all clear color and outline. The light of the world grew dim. Then those large and small remnants turned into one murky “clump” after another, each with a blurred outline. These clumps floated in endless darkness, bumped together again and again, and fused into even more twisted, grotesque shadows.

No one knew how long passed. At last, among all things that had almost sunk completely into darkness, dim currents of light appeared. They looked like the souls that remained after the world burned out and went dark, like the last glow in a bed of embers. Those dim streams of light flowed among the clumps of grotesque shadows, drifting without order through Duncan’s field of vision.

Deep in those dim, chaotic currents, in the wreckage left by the world’s collision, only one shape was left that still kept a faint outline.

It was a gigantic tree.

She floated quietly in the darkness of Universal Extinction, drifting in the time and years that had stopped moving after the Day of Ruin.

She was already dead, truly dead back when the worlds crashed together. The clash of laws and order wiped out all things. The gods died first in that process, and the World Tree created by the gods was no exception. Atlantis was only a phantom now, already long gone.

Yet she could not truly die.

Because in the elves’ deepest memories, there was always a World Tree like this.

Even if the elves themselves had been made again. Even if, in the third Long Night, the “Abyssal Lord” had rebuilt the elves. After seeing the true face of the Great Annihilation with his own eyes, Duncan already faintly understood what all “things” in the current Deep Sea age really were at their core.

Nothing could escape the clash of laws in the world’s collision. Not the mightiest warrior of any kingdom. Not the World Tree created by the deity. Not even the deity itself.

Duncan did not know exactly what kind of beings the present “Four Gods” were, including “Everburning Ember” Tarrigan. But he was sure of one thing: strictly speaking, this entire Deep Sea age was only something the Abyssal Lord rebuilt from a “blueprint” after the third Long Night.

Everything was embers.

Duncan quietly gazed at Atlantis, the tree that floated calmly in the dark. He watched her remains and the chaotic shadows around her, which had once been the homeland of a race.

The “World Tree” that appeared in the elves’ racial memory was, strictly speaking, also only a replica—but she could not understand that.

In the same way, she could not recognize the “elves” reshaped from ash.

Faint light slowly spread out from Atlantis’s remains.

Specks of flowing light seeped out of the dead tree like fireflies. They slowly gathered into a river in the chaos, winding and flowing. It circled gently around Atlantis’s roots, just as, long ago in the forests of the elves’ home, a river once flowed through the land and nourished the World Tree.

Every point of light in that river was a sleeping mind.

Fed by this “river”, Atlantis’s remains began to grow once more. Still a dead “corpse”, the branches of the World Tree rose in a strange way, stretching outward. From their edges grew fine, twisted, gray?white leaves, like a corpse climbing up from its grave, trying to crawl out of the land of the dead and into the living world.

Ted Riel’s last resistance had failed.

Duncan reached out his hand.

In the darkness, the Vanished sailed in silence toward that pale, twisted “tree of death”, a charred ruin that still kept growing and spreading.

Chapter 644:

Everything had already fallen silent. The howling and roaring from when the two worlds collided had vanished. The colors and sunlight of the mortal world had dissolved into the final Great Annihilation. In the chaotic darkness after the Universal Extinction, the dead World Tree was still growing quietly.

New remains grew from old remains. New ruins bred within the ruins.

She had forgotten the Elves, forgotten herself, forgotten every beginning and every end. Breeding, spreading, continuing to grow—these had become Atlantis's only obsession after the End.

But the Vanished came before this ever-growing corpse, and the eerie green glow of the green flame spreading through the darkness became a barrier that stopped Atlantis from spreading further.

The dead World Tree finally reacted.

Duncan saw unusual light and shadow suddenly ripple within her remains. It was a hazy mist. Vague limbs and shapes seemed to hide inside the gray-white fog. The edge of the mist kept spreading out from the canopy, like tentacles, or like twisted roots.

It reminded him of the mist that had floated above the Pilgrimage Ark of the Four Gods Church.

But before he could think more, a greater change occurred. The "river" that had been orbiting Atlantis, woven from countless tiny points of light,

suddenly broke apart. Innumerable sparks of radiance merged into the mist floating above the World Tree. In the next second, the mist that had seemed so unreal and weak suddenly solidified and then surged outward in a wild expansion.

The edge of the mist turned into a sharp spearhead, hurling itself with all its strength against the sea of spirit form fire that spread around the Vanished.

A deep, unreal rumble seemed to echo in the darkness. Atlantis's impact sent ripples through the spirit flame, but only more fire surfaced from the void, slowly staining the chaotic pale mist with ghostly green. Yet Atlantis kept ramming into it. Even though every collision burned her in a deadly way, the impacts never stopped for a single moment.

Duncan even felt a flash of shock.

For the first time, something dared to charge straight into that spirit form fire.

In the next second, as Atlantis kept striking, he saw a hazy figure slowly taking shape within the mist above the World Tree.

It was a faint glow with no clear outline at all, like a soul still brewing, not yet formed.

But Duncan realized at once that this was Atlantis.

He could not help speaking to that faint light: "This is meaningless. You cannot break through this barrier. Very soon, you yourself will become part of it."

Yet the faint light did not answer. There was only the constant impact. The border of the mist melted a little with each collision, and the low rumble turned into clear, repeated boom-boom sounds.

Duncan watched with a tense face. After a long time, he slowly raised his hand.

Flames rose out of the unreal and slowly flowed through the darkness toward Atlantis's true body.

He said in a low voice: "Release those Elves, and everything else you swallowed. Let Lightwind Harbor return to the Mortal Realm. While it is still not too late, there is still a chance to save things."

The hazy faint light finally reacted. It suddenly flickered, and a sharp, childlike voice rang out in the darkness: "They are not Elves!"

The points of light that had been drifting and gathering around the remains of the World Tree suddenly became wildly restless. More radiance flowed together like water and surged toward the mist above Atlantis.

Yet just as the mist was gathering itself for the next strike, the restless points of light shuddered violently again. Then many of the lights that had already merged into the mist abruptly flowed backward, breaking free from Atlantis's pull. Like scattered petals, the tiny lights fell from above the World Tree and drifted around the giant trunk like stars.

In the next second, one of those falling points swelled and slowly took the shape of a vague shadow—

It was an Elf, not very tall, with hair already graying, wearing a dark blue academy robe. A tired look seemed fixed forever on his face, yet now his eyes were calm as he stood among the countless drifting lights, quietly facing the World Tree that loomed in the darkness, huge as a mountain.

Ted Riel, Truth Keeper of Lightwind Harbor.

Duncan looked at the sudden figure in some surprise and said: "I thought you were dead."

Ted Riel only shrugged: “It was just a nightmare—still not as bad as grading all the homework and papers students rush out on the last day of vacation.”

Perhaps because so many Elves had suddenly slipped from her control, Atlantis’s mind-entity seemed stunned and confused for a brief time. But soon, her voice sounded again in the darkness: “Come back… hurry back, it is dangerous out there! Come back… let us wait together for Saslokar to come home, all right…”

At the edge of the spirit flame, a huge black billy goat suddenly stepped out of the fire. It lifted its head and calmly turned its gaze on the pale, twisted World Tree and said: “I am right here, little sapling.”

Atlantis suddenly froze. Her mind-entity wavered inside the mist, as if unable to tell whether the Black Goat in the flames was really the Creator from her memory. For a moment, she seemed to waver. The mist spreading from the crown quietly drew back, yet in the next second, a sharp howl and harsh noise swept across all the darkness:

“No! Wrong! You are not! None of you are! You all…”

She broke off suddenly, and in her confusion lowered her voice, muttering to herself: “You are not… you are… dead? You died… you are not Elves… I…”

A voice appeared out of nowhere and said: “We are indeed not the Elves you remember, Atlantis.”

That voice was not loud, yet it seemed to echo through the whole space. It sounded old, but it carried a calming strength.

On the deck of the Vanished, an old man with a hazy, unreal body slowly walked forward.

Rune turned back and gave Duncan a slight nod. Then he turned calmly, his expression steady, and directed his gaze toward the giant tree in the darkness.

That was the World Tree of Elven legend—their homeland, their Mother, their myth, their heritage, the starting point of all their tales and the source of a glorious civilization.

Now she had been dead for a long time, yet her remains had slowly fallen into a runaway state, swelling and growing even in death.

Rune had never seen a tree so huge. As an Elf, he had not even seen a forest, nor did he know how to live in one. He had never seen a winding river pass through a valley and turn into a babbling stream beneath the trees, never seen birds and beasts dwell in the woods, flowers blooming in clearings, and he had never heard the sound of wind and the sea of trees under the veil of night.

It was said that back then, Elves lived even longer than now—their lives were almost eternal, and under the protection of the World Tree they could be reborn from death. They were light and strong, able to run among the crowns of towering trees…

But Rune had never seen any of it.

He was born after all of that had been destroyed.

He walked to the end of the deck. Age had made his back a little bent, and years of desk work and poor habits had left him slightly overweight. When he lifted his head, wrinkles piled across his forehead like deep lines.

He said to the World Tree: “We must look very different from how you remember us.”

Atlantis did not speak. The faint light only trembled slightly in the mist, and from deep within the pale, twisted remains of the World Tree came a faint

rustling, like leaves stirring.

After a long time, the young voice finally sounded again, hesitant: “Those lines on your face… what are they?”

Rune said slowly: “They are wrinkles. When a mortal grows old, the skin loosens and shrivels, and it becomes like this. And when it is cloudy or raining, my back and waist ache, because I am already old and have always lived at sea… My stomach is not very good now, and my teeth have been patched. Maybe in a few more years, I will die like other old people. I will turn into ashes in a furnace, become fertilizer in a plantation… We will not return to the World Tree, and we will not be reborn in giant seed pods…”

He stopped and kept his head raised, turning his gaze toward that distant faint light.

He said again: “We are very different from what you remember, aren’t we?”

From deep within the remains of the World Tree, the faint rustling sounded again.

“…So none of it can come back… can it…”

Rune said slowly: “Yes. It cannot come back. None of it can. And even if it did, it might not be what you knew. But… there are some things I would like to show you.”

As he spoke, he reached into his coat and fumbled around. A moment later, he took out a book.

The book was very old and looked well-thumbed. Elegant letters were printed on the cover, in a script different from the common language used in most city-states.

He opened the worn book, found a passage, and read it slowly: “…The first sunlight fell upon the great rock. The traveler readied his pack. He would

cross the hill of flowers and reach the hill of Roland Nam before dusk…”

The young voice in the distance murmured: “This is from the ‘Horo-Dazzo Epic Poem’…”

Rune answered in a low voice: “Yes, that poem. Long ago, explorers found stone tablets carved with it on dark islands, along with many other records. We spent a thousand years reclaiming the meaning of these words, and then several thousand more searching for the hill of flowers and that slope described in the poem… But we never found them. Even those dark islands themselves vanished one day into the mist at the border…”

Rune spoke in a low voice. He set the book down and looked again at the distant faint light.

“We have recovered many things. Half of them we still cannot understand, but compared to humans and Senkin, the Elves have the most complete history. At least we still remember that the Creator woke in the darkness and planted the First Tree in the dream of origin… Four hundred years ago, we restored the craft of the ‘Ring-Tailed Lyre’. Its sound was clear and bright, just like the ancient scrolls described. Seventy-six years ago, we repaired the last chapter of the ‘Heidran Psalms’. It holds many interesting stories and is said to have been offered to the God…

“But there is much more that we still do not know, and never will. Those things vanished in the Great Annihilation and left no trace in the age of the Deep Sea, just like those dark islands that disappeared into the mist.

“Atlantis, I am sorry. We are not the Elves you remember. We only picked up a few fragments from the long river that rushed past and tried our best to leave these traces in the world after Doomsday… I do not know if that gives you any comfort, but…

“This is truly all that is left.”

In the darkness, the faint light floated quietly. The hazy pale mist slowly drew back. Without anyone noticing, the dead, twisted branches at Atlantis's edge had silently faded away, and the ghostly green flame now quietly encircled the giant tree, like… a forest that had vanished long ago.

Duncan lifted his head and looked at the huge black billy goat.

After a moment of silent exchange, he gave a small nod.

The Black Goat stepped forward, crossed the empty air, and slowly came to the foot of the giant tree.

He lifted his head and said softly: "…You have grown so much."

The faint light in the darkness trembled slightly: "I… I did not finish what you told me to do."

The Black Goat slowly lowered his head. He gently tapped his horn against the dry, torn trunk. At the tip of the horn, a point of ghostly green flame quietly burned. He said: "No, you have done very well. Now the good child needs to sleep, little sapling."

Within the pale mist, that faint light slowly dimmed. The sound of wind and rustling leaves finally fell silent. The scattered points of light flowed together into a river that quietly circled the base of Atlantis. From the deepest part of the World Tree, a wailing sob finally rose.

The ghostly green fire of the spirit form leaped up and, in an instant, wrapped the entire giant tree, lighting up all the darkness that had followed the Universal Extinction.

Chapter 645:

The flames rose.

It was as if a fountain of fire as tall as a mountain burst out in the darkness. The last remains of the World Tree turned at once into ash and phantom in the flames. Then the fire wound and flowed, spreading through the dark, chaotic space into a boundless sea of fire. That sea of fire burned away the last borders of the Nameless One’s dream and drove all things back to their “proper place” in the Mortal Realm.

The Boundless Sea appeared. Its endless waters rippled with tiny waves beneath the heaving flames. The sky appeared, pushing back the darkness above the fire and slowly brightening. The city-state appeared. It took solid shape as the flames surged upward, and as the flames faded, every lamp within it slowly lit up.

The whole world seemed to rise out of the darkness, slowly emerging from the sea of fire and once more merging with the Mortal Realm. Duncan stood at the bow of the Vanished and watched it all. For some reason, he suddenly recalled the ancient Elven legend: in Saslokar’s first dream, all things in the world were shaped out of dark chaos.

What he saw before him looked like that “Genesis Protocol” from the legend happening once again.

And at the end of the Genesis Protocol, sunlight appeared over the endless blue waves of the sea.

At some point, the flames had begun to fade. Morning sunlight spread in from the farthest edge, splendid and grand as it covered the endless sea and Lightwind Harbor, which was slowly waking to the dawn. The nightmare was fading. Everything that had been swallowed by it would return to the Mortal Realm as the sunlight rose—and those things that had briefly reappeared in the dream now also had to return to what they had been.

The huge black billy goat stepped on the waves and, with a single stride, came to the side of the Vanished. The ancient God once seen as the "Creator" lowered his head a little and pressed his sharp horn against the tall mast.

A point of ghostly green flame leaped at the tip of his horn and returned to the Vanished.

He said: "I return the fire to you, Captain."

Duncan looked at the Black Goat and said: "I could have handled it myself. You did not have to…"

The Black Goat shook his head and said: "But it was most fitting that I did it myself. A very long time ago, I created her. Now it should also be me who sees her off on her final journey."

Duncan did not answer, only gave a slight nod.

The Black Goat went on: "…Do not feel regret for this. It was something that was bound to happen. In a way, it had already happened long ago—Atlantis had ceased to exist even before the age of the Deep Sea began. What appeared in the nightmare was only a runaway shadow. Letting that shadow keep growing would have been the greatest insult to her. Besides…"

He paused suddenly, and Duncan asked with some curiosity: "Besides?"

The Black Goat seemed to smile a little and said: “Besides… you have already taken her away, have you not?”

Duncan raised his eyebrows at that. He understood at once what Saslokar meant, and it surprised him: “It seems you have sensed a few things.”

The Black Goat said slowly: “Not clearly, but I can vaguely feel it.” The ghostly green flame rising from the deck of the Vanished was reflected in his eyes. Not long ago, he had briefly been granted that fire and, within it, had felt a trace of Duncan’s true power. “Your flame took Atlantis to a ‘place’ I cannot understand. I do not know what that place is, but my instincts say it is good, very suited for my little sapling to have a long sleep.”

The sunlight grew brighter. The splendid double rune rings of Vision 001 were slowly rising above the sea’s surface. The morning sunlight shone on the Black Goat’s body, giving that huge form a crystal-like, half-transparent unreal texture.

The Black Goat lifted his head, glanced at Vision 001 in the distance, and said with some feeling: “The dream is over. Time to return to our posts. They really have built something remarkable…”

In the next second, the Black Goat’s body quietly cracked in the morning glow, like a soap bubble pricked under sunlight, and it vanished silently into the wind.

Duncan stood dazed on the deck for a while. Then he turned and looked at Rune standing not far away. The old Elf’s body had already returned to normal. He stood slightly bent in the rosy light, his expression still a little blank.

Duncan said casually: “I thought you would come greet Saslokar. He is the Creator from your legends, and you may be the last Elf to see him in his

Mythic Form—I do not have the energy to let him take that form very often."

Rune finally snapped out of his daze. He gave Duncan a slow look, then suddenly slapped his palm in regret and said: "Ah! I did not react just now!"

Duncan: "…"

After staring for two seconds, Duncan's mouth twitched. He said: "It is fine. You can still talk with him. You will just have to go to the captain's cabin and chat with my First Mate Goathead from now on."

After he finished speaking, he ignored the way the "Pope's" expression suddenly turned strange, waved his hand, and walked toward the rest of the deck.

Nina was already running happily toward him and called out: "Uncle Duncan!"

Duncan raised his arms to catch this "little Sun" as she leaped at him from midair. Then he lifted his head and looked at the others walking over.

Vanna came up to him, lifted her hand to point at the city-state not far away, bathed in sunlight, and said: "Lightwind Harbor seems to be restored. I just do not know how things are inside the city."

Lucretia said: "Once we dock, I will go check the situation in the city. In theory, based on how the Nameless One's dreams worked before, everything should restore itself when the dream ends. But this incident was so large. There will likely be some 'aftereffects' left behind."

Morris also walked over, but his gaze went another way. The Cathedral ship, which looked like a small city-state, was sailing through the waves, clearly headed toward the Vanished floating on the sea.

Morris said: “The Academy Ark is approaching. Looks like they want to talk with us.”

Duncan said as he raised his hand to point at Rune, who was heading toward the captain’s cabin: “That is normal. Their ‘Pope’ is still on our ship. You should go greet your mentor too. You two have probably not seen each other in the Mortal Realm for many years.”

Morris nodded and started toward the captain’s cabin.

Duncan turned his head to glance at Vanna and asked with some concern: “Are you really all right already? Do you not need to go back to your room and rest?”

He still clearly remembered that when he had just brought this valiant maiden back to the ship, she had used up all her strength and could barely walk. Now she already looked full of energy again.

Vanna also lowered her head to look herself over. She hopped in place twice, swung her arms and legs a bit, then patted her chest, a proud smile on her face, and said: “I am fine. I just rested for a while. My strength is completely back now.”

The corner of Duncan’s mouth twitched. For a moment he did not know what to say. Shirley, however, muttered under her breath to the side: “Man, the Athlete is really something… Burned to death by the Sun twenty-seven times, and after sitting on the deck to settle down for a bit, she’s already back to normal…”

Vanna immediately corrected her with a very serious face: “It was twenty-eight times. I was a bit scorched just now. I miscounted when I told you.”

Duncan: “…?”

He stared speechlessly as Vanna and Shirley walked off, still arguing over whether it had been twenty-seven or twenty-eight times. After a long while,

he finally smiled and shook his head.

“This is really nice.”

He heard Alice say softly not far away.

Duncan turned and saw Miss Doll sitting on a large barrel at the edge of the deck. She faced the direction of the sunlight, head lifted and eyes half-closed, letting the light spill over her face. Her legs swung lightly over the rim of the barrel, and her body swayed a little with them.

“It is really nice…” she sighed softly again.

Duncan walked over and suddenly asked beside the doll: “What is nice?”

Alice let out an “Ah” and almost fell off the barrel on the spot. Only when she saw it was Duncan did she relax. She grabbed his arm, used the force to steady herself back onto the barrel, and said: “You scared me.”

Duncan laughed and reached out to pat Miss Doll’s hair: “What are you sighing about?”

Alice thought for a moment, then raised her hand to point toward the city-state and said: “The way things usually are is really nice. No huge fires, no strange tree. Everything looks like what I know. The ship is back on a calm sea, and we do not have to fly over weird, scary forests anymore… I can scrub the deck like usual again, and go back to the kitchen to cook.”

As she said this, Miss Doll suddenly seemed to remember something. She jumped off the barrel at once and ran off, waving back at Duncan without turning her head: “the Sun is up! I have to go make breakfast! Captain, wait for me!”

Duncan watched in mixed surprise and amusement as that scatterbrained doll dashed across the deck. On the way, she was tripped by a rope that suddenly popped up, crashed right between Shirley and Dog, and stirred up

a whole noisy commotion. Vanna hurried over to look for the doll's head, which had rolled off to who knew where…

In almost the blink of an eye, the Vanished had returned to its usual "lively" state.

After a long time, Duncan smiled and shook his head. He pulled back his gaze and looked again at the large barrel Alice had been sitting on. He lifted his foot and gave its side a little kick: "Do you all also think it feels good to return to everyday life like this?"

The barrel wobbled in place, and its lid suddenly popped open.

Inside, the barrel was packed full with Wave Amulets.

Used by the Athlete as a container to pile amulets in, by the doll as a chair, often turning into Dog's homework desk and Shirley's target for random doodles, the barrel did not seem very happy.

Duncan's expression turned a bit odd. He quietly reached out and closed the lid again.

Then he sat down on the barrel as well, quietly gazing at the sunlight in the distance.

The world had returned to peace again, for now—but it was truly nice.

Chapter 646: A Temporary Farewell

With a rush of air surging out of the pipes, a loud, lingering whistle rose from the upper levels of the Truth Academy Ark. The Vanished once again pulled in beside the steam-powered mechanical dock at the far end of the Ark's shoreline. Knowledge guards and scholars in dark blue robes appeared on the gangway, ready to welcome their Pope back.

On the aft deck, Duncan saw Rune, who had just come out of the captain's cabin.

The short, plump elf elder had been inside the cabin this whole time, talking at great length with the "creator" of his race. Duncan had no idea what he and Goathead had talked about. He only knew that when Rune stepped out of the cabin, his expression looked a little blank.

There was also a kind of calm on his face, the empty sort that came after draining one's thoughts.

Duncan walked up to this "Pope of Truth" and greeted him several times before Rune finally snapped out of his daze and emptiness.

"Your Cathedral ship is already waiting alongside," Duncan said as he raised his hand and pointed past the rail at the gigantic Ark outside, which looked like a small city-state. "The scholars and guards have come to take you back."

Rune looked up, then belatedly nodded: "Oh… right, it is time to go back."

Seeing the elf elder's reaction, Duncan could not help feeling a little puzzled: "What did you talk about with Saslokar? You weren't in this state when you first came aboard…"

"We talked about… a lot of things," Rune said slowly, as if he did not even know where to begin. "A great many things."

Duncan frowned slightly and began to understand: "So you saw what the First Mate is usually like."

Rune jolted, as if he truly returned to himself only then. He lifted his head to look at Duncan, hesitated for a long time, and finally spoke: "…Why does He talk so much?"

"I'm more surprised that He talks so little when He's in His Mythic Form," Duncan laughed, and there was a trace of genuine amusement in his smile. "What you see now is how He usually behaves on my ship—in stricter terms, it's how He acts as 'Goathead'."

Rune opened his mouth, as if he wanted to say something but could not find where to start. After holding it in for a long time, he suddenly relaxed and laughed: "…It's not a bad thing. He seems to really like being that way."

The deck fell quiet for a while. No one paid any attention to the Pilgrimage Ark waiting nearby to take the Pope back. After an unknown time, Duncan finally broke the silence: "How do you plan to handle the 'truth' of this incident? Especially the part about Saslokar."

"Most of it will be restricted to the upper ranks of the Four Gods Church," Rune said. "Just like with all supernatural incidents that point toward a God, we will seal the information, handle the aftermath, and carefully assess the long-term impact of this incident on the Mortal Realm. As for elven society…"

Rune paused here, thinking. After a moment, he gently shook his head.

“The ancient days are already gone. Legends… should be allowed to keep sleeping as legends. That is also ‘His’ wish.”

“That’s good. I don’t like trouble,” Duncan nodded, then shifted the topic. “But there is something I need to remind you of—this is the third city-state.”

Rune at once understood what Duncan meant, and his expression grew solemn.

“Pland, Frostholm, Lightwind Harbor… The cause and course of each incident looked different. Each one seemed like an isolated ‘special disaster’. Every time, the biggest culprit behind it all seemed to be that group of cultists. But a bunch of cultists alone cannot pry at the very foundations of the world’s order,” Duncan said seriously. “What these incidents really show is that the world’s ‘keystone’ is starting to shake. I want to know whether the Four Gods Church has any way to deal with this, what you truly know, and what plans you have in place.”

Rune fell into a deep, dark silence. After a long time, he finally gave a small nod.

“I understand what you mean… and now I have confirmed your stance as well. At least by my own judgment, this is indeed the time to put aside suspicion and step up our cooperation.”

Duncan watched him: “But you still have to consider the reactions of the other Three Gods’ churches, don’t you?”

“It’s not just their reactions… There is also the reaction of the Gods,” Rune said calmly. “I will discuss this with the other three Popes as soon as possible. No matter what the result is, I will give you an answer—and likewise, no matter what the result is, at the very least, the Truth Academy

will from now on show the Vanished Fleet the greatest possible trust and cooperation."

Duncan nodded. He knew this was the greatest promise the other side could give him at this stage.

Just then, Rune seemed to recall something and suddenly said: "There is one more thing—I have heard about Miss Vanna's experience in this incident. I think… at the very least, the Flamebearer side will come looking for you soon."

"Flamebearer?" Duncan frowned, then immediately understood.

He turned his head and looked toward the other side of the deck. Vanna was leaning against a pillar by the rail, letting the sea breeze wash over her as she seemed to rest with her eyes closed. But Duncan's attention was not on her, it was on the thing lying beside her.

It was a huge, strange Gatekeeper's cane, as thick as a tree trunk. Its tip bulged like a giant, oddly shaped boulder, while the shaft was straight and rough. The entire Gatekeeper's cane was covered in carved markings that looked like mysterious symbols.

That was what the giant named "Tarrigan" had left to Vanna—even after the Nameless One's dream completely scattered, this Gatekeeper's cane still remained. Along with that strange "miniature Sun", it had followed the Vanished back to the Mortal Realm.

"Everburning Ember, Tarrigan, the Flamebearers' God," Rune said quietly. "The 'giant' Miss Vanna met in the Nameless One's dream should have been an echo left behind in Atlantis's memory during the collision of two worlds, a phantom in the form of 'resonance'. Yet even if it was only a phantom, it was still a phantom of an Elder God. What He left behind has now crossed the boundary between dream and the Mortal Realm.

“That Gatekeeper’s cane… if I’m not mistaken, it should be the ‘Chronicle Pillar’ that the Flamebearers worship. On Frem’s Pilgrimage Ark, there is a device that looks almost exactly the same, and it is regarded as the heart of the Ark. Its size is much larger than that ‘Gatekeeper’s cane’, though. I have seen it. It looks more like a gigantic monument…

“And that ‘Chronicle Pillar’ built on the Flamebearers’ Ark is actually a ‘replica’ made according to the descriptions in the Sacred Tome. For a very long time, the true ‘Chronicle Pillar’ existed only in legend.”

Duncan thought for a moment: “So you mean the Gatekeeper’s cane Vanna brought back is the ‘genuine article’ described in the Sacred Tome.”

“I can only say it is the closest thing to the ‘genuine article’ that we currently know of,” Rune said very carefully. “It is possible that there is no true ‘genuine article’ left in this world at all. The Great Annihilation ended everything. As we trace things back from the age of the Deep Sea, the farthest we can go is only infinitely close to that so-called ‘genuine article’.”

“Either way, it looks like that ‘Gatekeeper’s cane’ holds extraordinary meaning for the Flamebearers,” Duncan nodded lightly. “You think they will want to take it, is that it?”

“I’m not sure. Frem is a broad-minded, fair person. He never forces others and never seizes what does not belong to him. But… you know, that is still the ‘Chronicle Pillar’ left behind by Everburning Ember. Whether for the Flamebearer sect or for Senkin, its meaning is far too special.”

Duncan said nothing. He simply watched the “Gatekeeper’s cane” lying beside Vanna with a quiet gaze and thought in silence.

For some reason, he found himself thinking of that longsword that had once been thrown toward the sky.

He had given that sword to the research institute in Lightwind Harbor, because for him the only important thing about it was the “information” it carried about another world. As for supernatural objects themselves, he was no professional researcher.

In the same way, the Gatekeeper’s cane actually had little meaning to him, even though it had once been held in the hand of Everburning Ember, Tarrigan. Duncan only cared about the “truth” and “knowledge” of the Great Annihilation. Once he had gained that part of the information, he did not care much about anything else.

There were countless supernatural objects in this world, but for Duncan, most of them were worthless—not worth taking up even a single spot aboard the Vanished.

The problem this time, however, was that this Gatekeeper’s cane had been left to Vanna by Tarrigan.

He had to respect his crew member.

“Personally, I don’t mind handing the Gatekeeper’s cane over to the Flamebearers. After all, just like the ‘Horo-Dazzo Epic Poem’ in your hands is of great importance to the elves, the ‘Chronicle Pillar’ is indeed a relic of Senkin’s civilization,” he said openly. “But I have to consider what Vanna thinks. Since you already know about Vanna’s experience, you should know she treasures that Gatekeeper’s cane.”

He paused, then spoke very seriously to Rune: “That is her friend’s keepsake. I am not as broad-minded and fair as this Frem you talk about. I am protective of my own.”

“…I understand your stance,” Rune said, nodding with a solemn expression. “I will pass your words on to Frem and ask him to think very

carefully about this matter—to avoid both sides being put in an awkward position."

Duncan dipped his head slightly: "That would be best."

The loud, melodious whistle sounded again, and great clouds of steam rose like billows in the sky above the Academy Ark.

Rune took his leave from everyone aboard the Vanished. Then, under the watchful eyes of Duncan and the others, the elf elder stepped onto the gangway that led back to the Ark.

Driven by a massive steam engine, the mechanical gangway slowly retracted. Then, amid a series of heavy mechanical noises, the entire transforming dock structure folded back into the "shoreline structure" along the Ark's side. The vast Cathedral-ship, a city-state in its own right, let out a low rumble as it gradually pulled away from the Vanished.

But Duncan knew that this Ark would not return to the border right away. Rune had told him of his plans: the Pilgrimage Ark would remain in Lightwind Harbor for a while to help this "city-state just waking from a long dream" handle a series of aftermath matters.

That, however, no longer had anything to do with the Vanished.

Now, Duncan needed to deal with another matter that required "aftercare".

He walked to the door of the captain's cabin at the stern and pushed it open.

Chapter 647: Little Sapling

It was the same familiar room, with the same familiar furniture, the same small living room, the same studio apartment.

Everything still remained as it had been when he left, as if sealed in amber outside the flow of time. No matter how long had passed, nothing here seemed to change.

Zhou Ming stepped into the small living room of the studio apartment. Standing in the place where he had once lived for many years, he let out a soft breath.

He had not returned here for quite a long time—sometimes he even felt that he had already forgotten about this studio apartment, forgotten the “other world” it stood for.

But in the end, that self-deceiving “forgetting” meant nothing.

He shook his head with a smile, then walked straight toward the desk. He did not check the tightly closed window as he once did, because the clutter on the windowsill and the flour he had sprinkled there on purpose had already been cleaned away last time. In this last little room deep within the mist, he no longer expected any more Guests to visit.

A faint green ghostly light was slowly fading on the desk. As the flames receded, a new “collection item” gradually took shape.

Zhou Ming walked over and sat down in the chair, resting his hands on the desk. His gaze was calm and gentle as he looked at the little thing that

seemed full of life… the “little sapling”.

She floated above the desk. Her crown spread to about the length of an adult’s forearm, lush and full of branches and leaves. Her trunk was connected to a large clump of soil beneath her, her roots sunk deep into that soil, with a few roots stretching out underneath and exposed in the air.

She just floated there, about ten centimeters above the desk, maintaining that height in an… unbelievable way. She presented a style completely different from the rest of the “collection”.

Zhou Ming lifted his head and glanced at the big shelving unit not far away. The other collection pieces sat quietly in their own cubbies, resting safely on the wooden shelves.

Right now, this “little sapling” floating above the desktop was the only collection item that showed such obvious supernatural traits.

…Was it because her essence came from “dream”? So even after becoming a collection item here, she still kept some properties unique to creations of dream?

Half idly, Zhou Ming wondered that to himself as he reached out and gently brushed Atlantis’s crown. The “World Tree” that looked like a floating potted plant drifted aside from his touch, then slowly floated back to its original spot.

Aside from that, though, the little sapling showed no other lively traits. She did not speak, nor did she react in any other way to Zhou Ming’s touch.

“Now you really have become a little sapling again…” After quietly watching the tiny “World Tree” for a long time, Zhou Ming finally spoke in a low voice. “I don’t know if you can still hear this… To be honest, I don’t even understand the principles by which you all become ‘collections’ here after being burned by the spirit flame. But…”

He paused and glanced at the shelving unit. His gaze swept across the models of the Vanished, the White Oak, and the two city-states.

“But no matter how it works, this will be your new home from now on,” he said softly.

The models did not answer him, making him feel as if he were muttering to the air. If anyone else had been here, it would have been an awkward scene—but fortunately, there had not been any “outsiders” here for a long time.

He reached out with both hands and carefully lifted the clump of soil where Atlantis had taken root, then carried her toward the shelving unit in the corner. He was very careful, afraid that the loose-looking soil might crumble. If it fell apart, gathering it back together might not be so easy, and some dirt might slip into the gaps in the floor and be “lost”.

In this little room, “soil” was a precious resource.

But to his surprise, the clump of earth that looked so loose turned out to be quite stable, as if some invisible force was holding it together. On the way over, not a single grain of soil fell.

He set Atlantis in an empty cubby on the shelf, right next to the model of the Vanished.

The “little sapling” kept floating in the cubby, like a quiet potted plant.

Zhou Ming stood in front of his new “collection” and studied her for a while, but his feelings this time were no longer the same as before. All kinds of complicated thoughts rose and fell in his mind. After a long time, he finally let out a soft, relieved sigh.

At the very least, when he went back, he could tell Goathead that its “little sapling” really was still here.

“You shouldn’t need watering, right…” Zhou Ming suddenly thought of something and could not help muttering. “In theory you shouldn’t… And I hope you don’t grow any bigger. I don’t have that much space here…”

The “World Tree” in the cubby did not answer his muttering. Atlantis only floated there quietly, turning slowly.

Zhou Ming shook his head, then turned and sat down on the sofa in the little living room. He rested there for a while, then casually picked up a book from the small round table beside him and flipped through a few pages without any purpose.

There was no point in it. He had already read that book countless times. Its dry content no longer brought any joy in reading.

But he had grown used to doing something “meaningless” whenever he returned to this studio apartment—either sitting down to read a few pages, or writing two lines in his diary, or tidying up the clutter and cleaning a room that was already almost spotless.

For Zhou Ming, these things were like running a little shop in a city-state or working as a warden in a cemetery. They were not truly necessary, but they were like an Anchor of Humanity, letting him feel that he was still a human being, still living within “order” and “civilization”.

After a while, Zhou Ming set down the book and got ready to stand up and return to the Vanished.

But the moment he lifted his head, his movements froze. Half-risen from the sofa, he stared fixedly at the desk not far away.

Atlantis was now floating quietly several centimeters above the desk, as if she had been there the entire time and had never moved.

Zhou Ming blinked and, for a moment, even doubted his own memory. Then he frowned, walked over to the desk, and examined Atlantis from all

sides as she floated in the air. After that, he lifted his head to look at the empty cubby on the shelf.

After a brief hesitation, he picked Atlantis up again and carefully set her on the shelf.

He stared at that cubby for several seconds to make sure, then slowly stepped back and turned around. He walked a few steps away and then quickly snapped his head back.

Atlantis still sat obediently in the cubby.

Zhou Ming frowned, exhaled, and walked toward the front door of the apartment—but just when he was almost there, he suddenly stopped again and turned his head back without any prophetic omen at all.

Atlantis was once again floating quietly above his desk, as if she had never left.

Zhou Ming: "…"

He walked over with a straight face and stared unblinking at the "little sapling" hovering in midair.

"Are you doing this on purpose? Can you move around freely?"

Atlantis, of course, did not respond. She just stayed there quietly like a real tree.

Zhou Ming stared at the "World Tree" for a while longer, then picked her up and put her back in the cubby on the shelf. Right after, he turned his back and stood there for a while on purpose. Ten seconds later, he spun around—Atlantis was floating above the desk again.

The corner of Zhou Ming's mouth twitched. He strode up to the desk and pointed at it: "This is my desk. It's where I work. And if any new collection items show up later, they'll appear on this desk too."

Then he raised his other hand and pointed at the big shelving unit in the corner: “That over there is your place. The second cubby from the bottom is for you. You should be in your cubby, not occupying my desk!”

Atlantis gave no answer. She simply floated in the air, quietly turning in slow circles.

Zhou Ming’s eye twitched. He picked up the “little sapling” without hesitation and put her back on the shelf.

Then he stared at her for a long moment, turned around, and fixed his eyes on his desk.

Atlantis did not appear on the desk this time.

Instead, Zhou Ming heard a banging sound behind him.

He turned around and saw that Atlantis had somehow appeared in another cubby—the one that held the model of the White Oak.

Atlantis was using the big clump of soil at her roots to ram the hull of the White Oak again and again, making loud thumping noises. The model ship was on the verge of getting knocked off the shelf.

“Stop!” Zhou Ming reached out and pressed down on Atlantis’s crown. “You can’t knock into your ‘roommate’!”

Atlantis shivered under his hand, then suddenly swayed to the side. Zhou Ming felt his vision blur for an instant. When he looked along the direction of that last sway— The tiny “World Tree” was floating quietly above his desk.

Zhou Ming: “…”

A short while later, Duncan opened the door of the captain’s cabin and stepped inside, a trace of weariness on his face as he walked over to sit down at the chart table.

Goathead, perched on the edge of the desk, twisted its neck with a creak and fixed its gaze on the captain.

“Duncan Abnomar.” Before Goathead could speak, Duncan waved his hand and began on his own.

“Ah, Captain! You’re back. I thought you would come straight here, but I didn’t expect…” Goathead immediately perked up. With the fading of the Mythic Form, that familiar chattering energy had returned to the talkative wooden carving. But it quickly noticed the subtle look on Duncan’s face. “Uh… you look tired?”

Duncan waved his hand again and let out a sigh this time.

After several seconds, he lifted his head and met Goathead’s eyes: “Your little sapling has occupied my desk.”

Chapter 648: The Gods Are dead?

The captain’s cabin was very quiet. The faint sound of waves from outside came in, fine and gentle, and only made the stillness in the room stand out more. After quite a while, Goathead finally let out a sigh and said: “Ah, that sounds very good.”

Duncan raised his eyebrow and said: “I thought you would ask a few more questions. Aren’t you curious where exactly I took Atlantis? Aren’t you curious about all my secrets?”

Goathead answered bluntly: “Curious. But both reason and instinct tell me it is better not to pry into too many things people call ‘secrets’, especially not into what happens when you leave this ship. You are the captain of the Vanished. Knowing that is enough for me. As for everything else… the less I know, the better.”

“Instinct, hm?” Duncan spoke thoughtfully. He looked at the pitch-black wooden carving of Goathead in front of him and suddenly asked: “Did that instinct tell you what would happen if I were no longer the captain of the Vanished, or if you learned too many of my ‘secrets’?”

Goathead fell silent for a moment. After nearly a full minute, he finally broke the silence and said: “I only know that whenever I have the idea of Boundary Crossing, I see an endless starry sky—and under the light of those stars, the Vanished no longer exists.”

Duncan slowly furrowed his brow. After a brief moment of thought, he shook his head and set the tangle of ideas aside for now. He said: “Atlantis

is now staying in a safe place in a special state. You don’t need to worry.”

Goathead spoke softly: “Then that’s good.” He did not ask anything more.

After a few seconds of quiet, Duncan suddenly asked: “But there is still one question—what should I call you? Saslokar? Goathead? Or First Mate?”

Goathead thought for a moment. His tone even sounded a little awkward as he said: “…Let’s stick with the old way of calling me. First Mate or Goathead is fine. The name Saslokar… feels strangely unfamiliar. Thinking back now, it feels so distant that it doesn’t even seem like it was my own name.”

Duncan looked a little surprised and said: “But you agreed quite quickly when I first called you that.”

Goathead’s tone grew even stranger as he said: “…The mood at the time had already gone that way. It would have felt wrong if I hadn’t agreed…”

Duncan: “…”

He gave the pitch-black wooden carving on the table a strange look for a moment, then finally could not hold back his curiosity and said: “I’m very curious about what state you are actually in now—or rather… how you understand yourself. At the moment of the ‘world collision’, you could feel your change. At that time you seemed to have completely returned to your state as the King of Dreams, but it only lasted for a short while.”

Noticing the serious look on the captain’s face, Goathead finally started to think seriously. After a long while, he shook his head, not entirely sure, and said: “To be honest, I’m still somewhat confused even now. I could feel that the part of my memories that belonged to ‘Saslokar’ had awakened within my mind. But I could also clearly feel… he was not entirely me, and I was not entirely him.”

He went on: “But just as you said, when I saw Little Sapling… I changed a little. Perhaps it was the influence of my mythic form. Or perhaps Little Sapling had left such a deep mark in my memories that I… ‘returned’ to the state in those memories. For one brief moment, I even thought… that time had really flowed backward.”

He stopped, as if quietly recalling the strange feeling of that moment, recalling how something deep in his memory gradually revived and how another ‘personality’ awakened in his consciousness. But in the end, he slowly shook his head.

“But it lasted only a very short time. As the sunlight rose and the dream ended, I returned to this state,” Goathead said. “It seems that the symbiotic pact with the Vanished has permanently changed some part of my nature—and to be honest, I actually prefer being like this now.”

“Is that so?” Duncan said, once again thoughtful. “So you are now both Saslokar and not entirely him. That sounds more like a completely new individual reassembled from fragments of the Elder Gods… but if you feel this is good, then there is no problem.”

“Nothing wrong with it at all,” Goathead said in a carefree tone. “Some things… once they are past, they truly are hard to bring back. We all have to look forward. No matter how much the Great Annihilation took away, the fact now is that we are living in the Deep Sea era—so let Saslokar stay in legend.”

“…You have changed after all. In the past, you could hardly say something so reasonable so cleanly,” Duncan said as he gave Goathead a subtle look. He rubbed his chin and added: “But you reminded me. I just happen to have a question for you.”

Goathead’s tone immediately grew serious again as he said: “Please, ask.”

Duncan asked: “Saslokar died. He died long ago—do you still remember that sentence?”

Goathead thought for a moment, then gave a firm answer: “…I remember. When several parts of my memories were recovering and rearranging, that sentence kept echoing in my consciousness. It seemed to be a very strong kind of… ‘self-awareness’.”

“That’s right,” Duncan said with a nod. “Saslokar ‘died’ when the Great Annihilation happened. That is a ‘fact’ deeply imprinted in your memories, and even in the subconscious racial memory of the Elves. But according to the records in The Blasphemous Tome, during the second Long Night after the Great Annihilation, the ‘King of Dreams’ tried to create the world again and was ‘torn into pieces’ when the Genesis Protocol failed. The keel of the Vanished, the ‘Dream-Skull’ in the hands of the Annihilators, and you yourself are all evidence of that record.

“And we can be basically certain that the ‘King of Dreams’ recorded in The Blasphemous Tome was the same Saslokar who had already died during the Great Annihilation. How did an Elder God who had already died when the Great Annihilation occurred carry out a ‘Genesis Protocol’ during the second Long Night? Another similar contradictory record is Tarrigan, the ‘Everburning Ember’ worshiped by the Flamebearers.”

Duncan paused, picked up the glass of water on the table and took a sip. Then he adjusted his posture in the chair. With an even more serious expression, he continued: “Tarrigan was another ‘god’ who died when the Great Annihilation occurred. He was the patron of Senkin. According to the reports from Vanna and the records on that ‘Chronicle Pillar’, his death—or rather, his ‘fall’—was also an indisputable fact. But if he truly died when the Great Annihilation happened… then what is the ‘Tarrigan’ currently worshiped by the Flamebearers on the Boundless Sea? Who exactly is the ‘Everburning Ember’, one of the Four Gods?”

There was a faint creak from between Goathead's neck and base. He swayed his head from side to side, and after quite a while finally said with feeling: "That sounds a bit horrifying."

Duncan looked at the fellow quietly and said: "Don't talk like it has nothing to do with you. You are one of the 'gods' involved."

"I don't remember," Goathead replied with remarkable candor. "I've told you before, I only recalled some vague fragments of memory, and they all focused on the time before the Great Annihilation. As for what happened after that… I truly don't know."

Duncan furrowed his brow deeply and asked: "You have absolutely no impression of the second Long Night, or of your experience with the Genesis Protocol during that Long Night?"

Goathead thought very hard, then shook his head helplessly and said: "If I could remember even a little, I wouldn't be completely blank like this…"

Duncan ignored his nonsense. He simply frowned and kept thinking. After a long time he slowly said: "If that's the case, then I do have some guesses."

Goathead asked at once: "You have a guess?"

"I think we shouldn't simply apply the mortal state of life and death to a deity," Duncan thought for a moment and said with a serious face. "Let's use you as an example—do you think you are alive right now?"

Goathead froze for a moment. After thinking, he answered hesitantly: "I think… you could say I'm alive. Aren't I living just fine right now?"

"By 'living just fine', do you mean your spine is soaking in Subspace, one head has fallen into the hands of the Annihilators, and there are probably even more heads still drifting in the cracks of the world?" Duncan asked.

Goathead’s neck gave a sharp crack, and he immediately cried out: “Please don’t describe it in such a terrifying way! Why do I feel my hair standing on end when I hear that…”

“But that is exactly your current state—you have not only already died, you could even say… you died without much peace,” Duncan said. He also felt the topic was a bit eerie, but since he had already started, he could only force his face to stay serious and continue. “And I suspect the condition of the other ‘deities’ is probably not very different from yours.”

Goathead fell silent, as if caught in horror.

After briefly organizing his words, Duncan continued: “The Crawling King, lord of the Abyssal Deep. According to The Blasphemous Tome, He was the creator during the third Long Night. His current state is ‘having lost his sanity, stuck in the rift between the Abyssal Deep Sea, and Subspace, unable to move, constantly producing countless Abyssal demons and constantly devouring them’.”

“In the Sacred Tome of the Flamebearers, Tarrigan is described as a giant who guards the Primordial Flame, and that giant’s own body is also wrapped in undying fire that burns his flesh forever.”

“As for the Black Sun, I have seen Him,” Duncan said. “He is scorched by his own corona, his mind already shattered, and now he only longs to go out…”

“The storm goddess and the god of wisdom… I don’t know their exact state,” he added. “But I suspect it’s similar.

“Stripped of all mythic halos, just from my own ‘common sense’ and ‘subjective impression’, none of these situations is normal.”

Duncan said this and spread his hands, giving his final conclusion: “The gods are dead—it’s just that their ‘death’ may be very long, or very peculiar.

They do not ‘operate’ according to the ‘life and death’ that mortals understand. Some ‘state’ they remain in after death, or some ‘residue’, can still affect this world, or rather… affect these ‘embers’ that were burned to ashes after the Great Annihilation. This is the true face of the Deep Sea era.”

When Duncan’s words fell, the captain’s cabin fell into silence.

After who knew how long, Goathead’s voice finally broke the silence: “… The way you describe it… is disturbing. This time I really do feel my hair standing on end.”

Duncan thought for a moment and sighed softly: “…Maybe I really should use a gentler way to describe it. It does sound a bit eerie like this.”

“No, what I mean is, the back of my neck actually feels a bit itchy right now… would you scratch it for me?” Goathead said.

Duncan: “…”

Chapter 649: The Postponed Day of Ruin

Amid the embers that slowly cooled after Universal Extinction, the corpses of the Elder Gods ruled the ashes of the world, and certain things that ‘sprouted’ from those corpses built replicas and phantoms of the past among the ash. Stripped of every mythic halo, once he re-sorted all the information he had, the ‘Deep Sea era’ before Duncan showed its truest—and most chilling—face.

He could of course use milder phrases to describe this era, or use some more acceptable way to explain the current state of the gods, but that would not change the essence of things.

He stood up and scratched Goathead’s neck. This former ‘creator’ raised his head and studied Duncan’s expression. He said: “You look weighed down by worries.”

Duncan sat back down. After a brief silence he suddenly spoke, almost to himself: “…The whole world is just a heap of embers slowly going out…”

Goathead spoke at once: “I’ve heard Lucretia say that sentence.”

Duncan nodded and said nothing more. Instead he reached into his coat and rummaged around. After a moment of searching he took out two objects.

One was a ‘sphere’ that shone with brilliant light. It was an Ancient Star shrunk countless times over. Flames flowed over its surface, and gentle

radiance kept surging, returning, and rippling, as if it were truly maintaining the ‘operation’ of a star.

This was the ‘gift’ Vanna had received from Tarrigan. It was the Sun that had once belonged to Senkin.

The other was a piece of finely cut, pale-gold crystal about the size of a fist. It had dozens of irregular, asymmetrical faces. Each face showed a smooth, flawless texture, and within the crystal there seemed to be extremely intricate and delicate structures, as slender as strands of hair, spreading outward from the crystal’s center to form a three-dimensional lattice wrapped inside the crystal.

Goathead’s attention was first drawn to that ‘little Sun’, but it soon fell on the strange pale-gold crystal. After staring blankly for a moment, he asked in great puzzlement: “What is this thing?”

“If we go by the classifications of the ‘civilized world’, this should be some kind of ‘blasphemous archetype’,” Duncan said casually. “This is something that separated from the body of that Sunspawn when it fell from the sky—before the flames burned it away, AI ‘picked’ it up and brought it back.”

Goathead froze for a moment, then finally recalled the scene from back then —

In its final moments, the Sunspawn had tried to escape the dream of the Nameless One, but had been intercepted in the sky. At the time, he had given that freak its final blow in his mythic form. The thing had fallen from the clouds in pieces, and at the center of its shattered fragments something shining had seemed to be flung out. But the situation had been chaotic then. That thing had flashed once in the sky and had then been ‘swept away’ by a mass of eerie green flames, and no one had paid it any mind… so it turned out to be this?

A flurry of flapping wings sounded from the side as AI beat its wings and flew onto the chart table. It tilted its head to look at the strange crystal it had picked up. After watching it for quite a while, it stretched out its neck and tapped the surface of the crystal with its beak, crying: “The crystal is full of hatred! The crystal is full of hatred!”

Duncan ignored the stupid bird’s chatter beside him. He stared at the crystal before him in thought, and in his mind he recalled the strange large umbrellas held by those tall, thin men in black who were called ‘the Sun’s residue’. He remembered that inside those strange umbrellas, besides machinery and circuitry so delicate they far surpassed the age, there were also crystal structures cut with extreme precision.

These crystal-based ‘blasphemous archetypes’ seemed to be the unique ‘technological creations’ mastered by the Black Sun and His spawn and Remnant Folk.

Long ago, when he had first seen those strange large umbrellas in the hands of the men in black, Duncan had realized something. The Suntists possessed technological creations, which meant they were not a primitive tribe of savage chaos. The advanced manufacturing techniques shown in these blasphemous archetypes actually displayed an extremely advanced civilization.

Or rather, the ‘afterglow’ left by an extremely advanced civilization.

And now, after personally witnessing the truth of the Great Annihilation, Duncan had a new understanding of this matter.

The collision and annihilation of worlds had brought about the Deep Sea era, and the worlds that collided were by no means limited to the homelands of the Elves and of Senkin. The world of that warrior who had flung out his long sword, and Duncan’s own home world as well, had clearly all been destroyed together during the Great Annihilation. Reasoning from this,

every race now in this world, every style of relic, every inexplicable and mutually contradictory historical record, likely represented a civilization that had been destroyed.

Some of those civilizations might have come from different planets within the same universe. But those with huge discrepancies, enough to cause corruption to other ‘heritages’, clearly came from universes with different laws.

Duncan slowly furrowed his brow. He gently rubbed the surface of the crystal and murmured to himself: “Then the Black Sun… from which universe was He a leftover orphan? So they are also the Lost Ones…”

“Who?” Goathead did not react at first, but soon understood what the captain meant. “You mean the Black Sun and His freaks?”

“Everything in the Deep Sea era comes from those worlds that were destroyed during the Great Annihilation,” Duncan said slowly. “The Elder Gods are merely powerful individuals that survived in a half-dead state after the Day of Ruin. The Black Sun could not have appeared out of nowhere—this crystal should represent the civilization that ‘the Sunspawn’ once belonged to.”

Goathead thought for a while and then slowly said: “…But now this ‘civilization’ stands on the opposite side from us. Their very existence is a kind of destruction for the whole Mortal Realm world. The Black Sun wishes to extinguish himself, while His spawn are obsessed with destroying the Mortal Realm dimension and letting the Black Sun ‘be reborn’ from the ruins of the mortal world. They may once have been a glorious civilization, but now they are mad from top to bottom. It is clearly impossible for them to coexist with the mortal world.”

“Exactly. They cannot coexist,” Duncan said. “There are many other things in this world that cannot coexist with the civilized world—dangerous Elder

Gods, the shadows in the Spirit Realm, and those things in Subspace… But have you thought one level deeper—why can't these things coexist with the mortal world?"

Goathead was taken aback and seemed to fall into thought.

Duncan said: "Everything is 'ash' left behind after the Great Annihilation. The gods' corpses opened the present Deep Sea era from within the ash. In theory, the current Deep Sea era is already the result of the worlds in the Great Annihilation merging with, reshaping, and compromising with one another. In other words, since the Great Annihilation has ended, and the third Long Night has successfully remade the world, what exists in the world now is already the 'rebalanced' result. There should no longer be the same mutual corruption and contamination as during the collision of worlds…"

"But in reality, there are still Elder Gods like the Black Sun," he went on. "There are still many 'corruptive things' that will cause disasters as soon as they appear in the Mortal Realm world. This kind of corruption is exactly the same as the 'corruption' that appeared around Atlantis during the Great Annihilation. It feels as if…"

Duncan stopped there, as if unable to find the right words for a moment.

Beside him, Goathead suddenly spoke: "As if the Great Annihilation has never actually ended?"

"Yes. As if the Great Annihilation has never actually ended," Duncan slowly nodded, his expression especially grave. "It has only been postponed, temporarily isolated somewhere, and then slowly released into the world as time passes. The corruption still exists, and the conflicts and corruption between different worlds are still going on slowly. The third Long Night forcibly 'pressed' the embers together, but within this barely

‘pressed-together’ order, the underlying opposition and destruction of all things has never stopped…”

Goathead gradually reacted and said: “This corresponds to that ‘dusk’ those Enders talked about…”

“Self-corruption and self-destruction are the destined path of the Deep Sea era. The Day of Ruin was set at the very beginning of history. Doomsday corrupts history and will eventually chase it down along the long river of time—that has always been the ‘gospel’ preached by those Enders,” Duncan slowly nodded as he spoke. “All along, this kind of Doomsday doctrine has been rejected by mainstream society. But after learning the truth of the Great Annihilation and combining it with the various ‘features’ of the current Deep Sea era, I had no choice but to start taking those madmen’s Doomsday theory seriously.”

At this point he paused, then went on as he thought: “Perhaps this is not really some Doomsday theory at all, but just a kind of objective description of the third Long Night. The third Long Night was an incomplete, unsuccessful Genesis Protocol. It did not fundamentally resolve the ‘conflicts’ triggered by the collision of many worlds. It only provided a buffer zone, so that within a term of ten thousand years this world could find its own way out… and that is why a fourth Long Night is needed.”

“…Do you think that ‘way out’ has appeared?” Goathead asked quietly.

“No,” Duncan shook his head. “Those Enders seem to know some things, but only what kind of ‘hidden danger’ the third Long Night left, and that the underlying conflict and collapse of all things in the world are going on slowly. If they truly knew how to solve this problem, they wouldn’t have treated the Annihilators and the Sunspawn as cannon fodder, and wouldn’t have sent them into the Nameless One’s dream to search for answers.

“The information they provided to the Annihilators and the Suntists were vague and ambiguous. It did not sound like clear guidance toward a definite goal at all, but more like some kind of test. That shows that those Enders themselves did not know what the correct direction was.”

Goathead stayed silent for a while, then suddenly asked: “How are you planning to handle this crystal? If it really is some kind of blasphemous archetype… then the longer this thing remains in the Mortal Realm world, the more dangerous it will become. Even if it is kept on the Vanished, it might not be safe in the long run.”

Duncan thought for a moment and slowly raised his hand.

Fine strands of flame rose from his fingertips and seeped into the crystal.

“I am very interested in their secrets,” he said.

Chapter 650: Memory of the Crystal

The flame seeped into the crystal and spread quickly through the three? dimensional structures inside it, as thin as strands of hair and so complex they made one’s eyes swim. As the flame poured in, Duncan’s consciousness gradually began to sink.

He felt that he had entered a vast, empty place, silent and cold.

It was as if this was a corner that had been forgotten for endless years. A nameless sense of isolation and loneliness rushed along with the flame almost at once. Right after that, he sensed light appearing in his field of vision—strong light, so huge he could hardly grasp its scale, and cold.

He opened his eyes and found himself standing on a huge block of black stone, floating in the void. A golden blazing sun burned quietly before him, so close it was almost terrifying. Flames rolled across its surface. Enormous structures like solar prominences rose into the void and then slowly sank back down again, all in utter silence.

Yet this blazing sun gave off no heat. Even at this distance, Duncan did not feel the terrible high temperature its sunlight should have brought when it shone on him. It only burned there, silent and cold, as if it were nothing more than a scene that had been recorded… an image.

Was this the Black Sun? Had he seen It again?

Duncan frowned and thought this instinctively. But right away, he realized that this heatless golden sun was not the same as the “Black Sun” he had seen before. Deep inside its shell he saw no hideous, eldritch tentacles, nor any dying, pallid eyeball. More importantly… this “Sun” did not try to cry out to him for help.

It was a recording, an image left behind by a real star!

Duncan reacted quickly. Then his gaze finally shifted away from that cold blazing sun, and he began to notice the “black monolith” beneath his feet.

It was a vast artificial construct.

Its surface was flat and smooth, cut by grooves and markings that were clearly carved by hand. The material looked like stone, yet it gave off a faint metallic sheen. At certain nodes in those grooves rose protrusions of unknown purpose, as if they were made from strange crystals.

Duncan let his gaze follow the edge of the monolith outward, toward the endless dark void around the golden sun—

He saw more such “monoliths”. Countless colossal black constructs like stone steles floated around the golden sun, drifting in the boundless darkness. They formed neat arrays, like walls thrown up in space. From this angle, he finally saw more detail on the sides facing the Sun. Precisely cut crystal surfaces covered one face of each monolith, reflecting the sunlight. Beneath the crystals seemed to lie intricate machinery, devices that could adjust the angles of the crystal arrays. The whole structure looked as if… it had been built to gather the energy released by the Sun?!

Duncan stared blankly at the array of monoliths floating around the Sun. In the darkness they formed a vast, loose spherical shell that enclosed the star at its center. Between each floating device he could faintly see twisted lines of light, like some kind of force field. And beyond that enormous “shell”, in

the depths of the endless dark, there seemed to be more hazy shadows. But they were too far away, and the sunlight too bright, for him to see them clearly.

What were those?

Distant planets? Habitats in space? giant ships? Or…

Centers that maintained and controlled this astonishing Dyson sphere?

He did not know how long it took before he finally drew his gaze away from the immense shell in space. Even after he understood what he was seeing, it took him a long time to truly come back to himself.

…Inside the crystal device the Sunspawn had left behind, what was stored was not some dark, forbidden truth or the corrupt knowledge of elder gods, but… the design of an ancient Dyson sphere.

Duncan narrowed his eyes a little.

No. This was exactly the dark forbidden truth and the corrupt knowledge of the elder gods. For the Deep Sea era, for the wreckage left behind by other universes, for all things that existed under other systems of mathematics, a Dyson sphere built and supported by parameters from an alien cosmos was the very height of taint and corruption.

After he recovered from his shock, Duncan walked toward the edge of the black monolith under his feet. At the same time, he recalled the “New Hope” he had once seen, the ship that had crashed into this world.

Had that ship also become this world’s “corruption”? After it fell… what had it turned into?

He walked to the edge of the stellar energy collector and looked down.

Sheer cliff?like metal casings and the endless distant darkness filled his view.

Duncan knew that here, strictly speaking, there was no such thing as up or down. If anything counted, only the pull of gravity from the distant star could be called “down”. Yet his senses still told him that the black device under his feet was the ground. Standing on its outer shell felt as solid as standing on earth—he would not fall into the endless void, nor be caught and drawn away by the Sun’s gravity.

That mismatch between what he knew and what he felt helped remind him at every moment that this was only an illusion, a vision recorded inside a “blasphemous archetype”.

What about deeper inside this record? Was there anything else?

Duncan sensed his own flame. He guided it to spread deeper into the crystal, letting his mind sink further down.

The splendid golden sun before his eyes vanished, along with the astonishing Dyson sphere.

Boundless darkness spread in from all directions and flooded his sight.

Contrary to what he had expected, he did not see the fall of the civilization that had built the Dyson sphere. There was no second World Collision. He seemed to skip straight past that stage, arriving instead in the dark chaos after Universal Extinction.

He did not know how long he lingered in that dark chaos. Just when Duncan was about to suspect that there truly was no more information in the crystal, faint lights suddenly appeared in his vision!

Several rays of light appeared. Within the glimmers seemed to be vague shapes—some vast, some uncanny, some twisted and without fixed form. He could not make out their true outlines at all, but he heard… “voices”.

Those voices sounded directly inside his mind—

“…Compatibility was far lower than expected. That ‘King of Dreams’ also failed… We must adjust the plan…”

“The Sanctuary World cannot protect everyone… Some entities have survival conditions that are far too strict. Preserving them while guaranteeing the others… the difficulty was too high.”

“…Draw up a list. Those not on the list…”

“Who will make that decision? On what standards will the list be based?”

“…First establish a compatibility threshold, then run simulations… LH?01 has calculated a plan. If we create a stable anchor, we can ensure the greatest possible number… but we will still have to abandon some…”

After that came a jumble of noise, as if that part of the record were missing. The noise left Duncan’s head spinning, but soon he heard clear messages emerge from it—

“…The entities on this part of the list cannot withstand transformation. The cost of preserving them is too high… We can only abandon them.”

“…There is still three percent redundancy. We can make a few more adjustments…”

“…They must live under a specific stellar environment. For the other entities, their sunlight is lethal poison… LH?01’s plan cannot meet this requirement… There is not much time.

“…Abandon them.”

Boom!

A hollow, echoing roar shattered all the voices and tore apart the endless darkness. Duncan had the sense that he had touched the very bottom of this information. No more messages rose up. In the roar and dizziness, his mind pulled rapidly back from the depths of the crystal.

He opened his eyes and saw the familiar cabin in front of him. The pale golden crystal lay in his palm. Under the burn of the eerie green flame, it quickly turned into a heap of ash.

The information carried in the crystal had been drained dry. This “blasphemous archetype”, which should never have existed in the Mortal Realm at all, lost its stability along with it.

Duncan rubbed his hands together. The last trace of ash in his palm instantly scattered into the air.

He looked up and met Goathead’s gaze.

“What did you see, sir?” Goathead asked a little tensely.

“…The process of them being abandoned. The contents of The Blasphemous Tome have been confirmed once again.”

Duncan did not hold anything back. He told Goathead everything he had seen and heard in the depths of the crystal.

Of course, he did not go into the details of things like “Dyson spheres”. That was not something he could explain clearly in a short time.

After he finished speaking, the captain’s cabin stayed quiet for a long time.

He did not know how long it took before Goathead finally stirred. Goathead spoke in a complicated tone: “…The Blasphemous Tome records that during the third Long Night, some ‘clans’ were cast out into the dark…”

Duncan nodded slightly. He also remembered that passage. It said that “the clans cast into the dark did not die—in their long exile they slowly twisted, becoming… something even more dangerous.”

Goathead thought for a moment, then suddenly asked: “What do you make of this, sir? Do you think the Sunspawn’s actions now… are understandable?”

“In things like this, talking about right and wrong is meaningless,” Duncan said, shaking his head. “The world was not built on fairness. I do not know what state this world was in after the Great Annihilation and before the age of the Deep Sea began. I do not know how many plans the Elder Kings who tried to build the Sanctuary World once had, or how many trade?offs they made. Judging the choices of those who paved the road while we stand in a safe era is foolish and short?sighted. Especially from where we stand now… any form of ‘sympathy’ is both unreasonable and unnecessary.”

“…You are correct, sir,” Goathead said softly after a brief silence.

Duncan said nothing more. He only nodded lightly, then let his gaze fall on the small “Sun” that Vanna had obtained from the giants.

Chapter 651: The Little Sun and the Little Sun

Even though he had already seen the “shrunken” Moon, Duncan still found all of this hard to believe now that he was truly seeing and holding this tiny Ancient Star with his own hands.

It rested in his hand, giving off warm light. The flames on its surface brushed harmlessly over his fingers, bringing only a very faint sensation, like feathers stroking his skin.

But Duncan knew that in some distant past, this small, radiant sphere had once lit the sky of Senkin and sheltered a whole civilization.

“…The followers of the Black Sun wanted this thing. One of the Spawn even risked itself for it. What do you think they wanted to do with this ‘Sun’?” Goathead asked. The sunlight shining from Duncan’s palm was reflected in its eyes, full of curiosity.

“Whether it was the Sunspawn or the remnants called the ‘Remnant Folk’, they had only one goal: to ‘revive’ their ‘mother’, the Black Sun that is now on the verge of death,” Duncan said. He carefully turned the “miniature star” in his hand without looking up. “This small sphere, which looks so insignificant, carries ‘information’ from before the Great Annihilation. For the Black Sun in its current state… it may be some kind of key material for self?repair.”

He paused for a moment here, then slowly voiced some ideas that had been taking shape in his mind.

“In that golden crystal, I saw the home where they once lived. They had a vast technological construct built around their star, and their whole civilization existed upon that structure. When the Great Annihilation happened, that enormous construct must also have suffered the ‘corruption’ of other worlds and twisted into what it is now…

“I have a bold guess. The so?called ‘Black Sun’ may be a kind of ‘hybrid’—their entire civilization, born around the star, and the star itself ‘collapsed’ together, mutating into its current form. Because of this ‘fusion’… the Black Sun is far more deranged and chaotic than other ancient beings, and has many more ‘missing pieces’.”

He raised his hand slightly and shook the Ancient Star in his palm.

“Those Sunspawn might think that another Ancient Star could help them mend the ‘missing pieces’ of the Black Sun,” he said. “I do not understand the principles behind it, but one thing is certain—if they truly succeeded, it would be a disaster.”

“…Fortunately, they failed,” Goathead said with genuine feeling.

Duncan nodded, then looked thoughtfully at the Ancient Star in his hand.

Just then, footsteps suddenly sounded outside the captain’s cabin, followed by a knock at the door. Nina’s voice came from outside: “Uncle Duncan! Are you in there?”

Duncan raised an eyebrow and answered at once: “Come in.”

The door to the captain’s cabin opened. Nina poked her head in for a look, then slipped inside with a grin: “Dinner is ready! I came to call you to eat!”

Duncan looked at Nina’s radiant smile, and a thought suddenly stirred in his mind.

“You came at just the right time,” he said, beckoning to the young lady. “Come and look at this.”

Nina came over obediently and at once noticed the “little Sun” in Duncan’s hand. She stared wide?eyed at the pretty glowing orb and quickly realized: “Isn’t this the ‘Sun’ Miss Vanna brought back from that desert?”

“Hold it,” Duncan said, casually handing the “little Sun” to Nina. “What do you feel?”

Nina took the small sphere, which was about the size of her fist, still a little puzzled. She held it up before her eyes and looked it over from side to side, then tried to “feel” it carefully. She looked at Duncan in confusion: “I don’t feel anything… It just feels warm.”

“Only that?” Duncan frowned. He instinctively wondered what other tests he should have Nina run. While his thoughts wandered for just that moment, a crisp crack suddenly reached his ears.

He looked up in astonishment and saw Nina staring back at him, just as dazed. A tiny wisp of flame and a spray of glowing crumbs were falling from the corner of her mouth. The surface of the Ancient Star in her hand was missing a small piece, and clear tooth marks showed along the broken edge.

Duncan: “…?!”

“I… I couldn’t help it!” Nina finally realized what she had done. She almost jumped on the spot, waving her hands. “I just thought it looked like a good size and then… then… I just bit it without thinking…”

“Don’t move around,” Duncan said quickly, cutting off Nina’s panicked flailing. He stood up and snatched the little Sun from her hand. He was afraid that the bite she had taken might have damaged the stability of this “star”. He had no idea how powerful a star compressed to this size would be

if it entered a runaway state, but it was clearly something extremely dangerous.

But nothing happened.

The “star” with a bite missing neither collapsed nor exploded. It still gave off mild, harmless warmth.

And when Duncan looked over its surface again, he realized that the little notch had vanished at some point.

Nina leaned in curiously, blinking at the “little Sun”, which had once more become a complete sphere. After a long moment she finally said: “It healed?”

Duncan gave the “little Sun” in his hand a strange look, then lifted his eyes to the “little Sun” hanging above the Vanished. He had seen all manner of bizarre anomalies and manifestations, yet now he suddenly felt that his mind might not be enough for this.

After countless absurd and uncanny notions rose in his heart, he handed the miniature “star” back to Nina: “…Take another bite.”

Nina obediently took the “little Sun” and bit into it again. There was another crisp crack, followed by loud crunching.

To be honest, just hearing it made Duncan a little hungry…

The next second, under the gaze of both Duncan and Nina, the “little Sun” returned to its original, flawless state.

Nina looked up at Duncan, then back at the “little Sun” in her hands, utterly puzzled: “…Why?”

Duncan raised a hand and rubbed his forehead hard—how was he supposed to know?!

“I suspect even the finest scholar in this world could not answer your question,” Duncan said as he kneaded his brow. He gave a strange look to the sparks of flame that had burst from the corner of Nina’s mouth, and after holding back for a long time, he finally could not resist asking: “…Is it good?”

“Crispy,” Nina replied honestly. “It feels great, but I can’t tell what it tastes like.”

“…Do you still want more?”

Nina’s eyes lit up at once (they truly lit up; the whole captain’s cabin brightened): “Can I?!”

Duncan: “…”

The captain’s cabin fell silent for a while. Duncan strained all his knowledge and imagination trying to explain how any of this was possible. Nina, meanwhile, held the “little Sun” and turned it over and over, as if she were looking for the next place to bite.

After an unknown time, Duncan decided to give up on understanding it.

“You don’t feel unwell at all, do you?” He shook his head. Suddenly he began to worry whether Nina’s body would have problems after “devouring a star”.

“No, I don’t. When I swallow it, it’s warm and really comfortable,” Nina said, shaking her head. “Uncle Duncan, can I have another bite?”

“…I suggest you at least not try again today,” Duncan said after thinking for a moment. His tone was serious, though his expression was hard to keep straight. “If you still feel fine tomorrow… then do as you like.”

He paused here, then added: “I originally meant to leave it in your care anyway.”

He was not lying. Before Nina came in, he had already been thinking about where to keep this “little Sun”. For reasons that were natural and obvious, giving it to Nina to look after seemed only fitting. First, there was an essential link between the two of them. With Nina keeping the “little Sun”, they might discover more of its secrets. Second, in terms of safety, a girl whose slap reached six thousand degrees had more than enough power to make sure no one could steal this “star”.

But the fact that his dear niece thought the “little Sun” tasted good… that part had not been in the plan at all…

Nina herself did not think much of it. She brightened at Duncan’s arrangement and nodded hard: “Mm!”

She looked just like a little dog that had finally gotten the bone it had been dreaming of.

Looking at Nina’s beaming smile, Duncan could not help but feel another thread of worry rise in his heart—

Was it really all right to give it to her?

For now, the “little Sun” seemed to recover at once after being bitten. But he did not know whether this recovery had a limit. If he handed it to Nina to “look after”… would she someday eat the whole thing?

“Uncle Duncan?”

The call at his side snapped Duncan out of his wandering thoughts. He hurriedly pushed the strange notions from his mind and turned his head to meet Nina’s bright, sunlit face.

“Are we going to eat?” Nina asked with a dazzling smile.

“…”

In the end, Duncan could not bring himself to take the “little Sun” back.

At the same time, the great Academy Ark had already sailed near the coast of Lightwind Harbor.

In a lounge on the upper deck of the ark, Rune sat in a chair with his eyes closed, resting.

From the state of the elves who had stayed on the ark, it was clear that the Nameless One’s dream had entirely faded from the Mortal Realm. Even the elves who had once vanished completely had now returned to the Mortal Realm.

Once the sudden pressure was gone, fatigue quietly rose up. Rune had been resting for a long time since returning to the ark; only now did he feel his strength somewhat restored.

After a long while, he slowly opened his eyes and looked at his own hands, at the wrinkled skin that no longer held much life.

“I really am old now.”

He muttered this with a sigh, then rose from the chair and walked over to the nearby workbench.

“…Time to have a talk with a few old friends.”

Chapter 652: Stepping Into the Mist

The flame on the alchemy platform began to burn silently. The liquid in the flask started bubbling. Rahm's gaze came from the mist deep inside Rune's thoughts, and Rune felt his consciousness pulled into a dark, deep place. After he passed through a long, unreal black "tunnel", he saw a few faint lights at its end.

They were his old friends – Helena, Banster, and Frem.

He walked up to the figures, but before he could greet them, Helena was the first to break the silence: "You look in pretty good shape, Rune – looks like we don't need to worry about the Truth Academy having to find a new Pope."

"Thank you for your 'concern'. It seems I am not going to be called to the Lord's side anytime soon," Rune glared at Helena, though there was clearly no real annoyance in his tone. Then he turned to the others and gave a small nod. "Sorry to keep you waiting – I needed some time to restore order on the ark, and to recover my own condition."

Tall and broad-shouldered, with skin like rock, Frem studied Rune's spirit projection carefully. His voice was low: "The incident is resolved?"

"It is resolved," Rune nodded and said. "Order in Lightwind Harbor is being restored. The elves in other parts of the world should also start 'waking up' one after another. In the end, the worst did not happen."

“…We want more information,” Banster spoke from the side. The tall, thin old man who followed the God of Death looked grave. “The influence of this incident spread far beyond the previous crises in Pland and Frostholm. It directly affected an entire race and pointed straight at history from before the age of the Deep Sea… What exactly happened in Lightwind Harbor?”

Rune fell silent for a moment. His gaze swept over the shadows before him and finally landed on Frem, leader of the Flamebearers. After thinking for a bit, he finally spoke in a low voice: “With Captain Duncan’s help, I witnessed the Great Annihilation – the final truth of our world, far beyond anything anyone imagined.”

Then he told his three old friends everything that had happened in the deepest part of the Nameless One’s dream. He told them about the great impact that destroyed two worlds, and the information about Senkin’s home world. He held nothing back.

Even for followers of the Four Gods, this information was far too shocking. After Rune finished speaking, the dark space held up by the psychic echo fell into a long silence.

“Worlds… colliding and merging?” No one knew how much time had passed before Helena finally broke the silence. In the darkness, she fixed her gaze on Rune’s eyes. “You mean the World Drift Theory has been proven?”

“We can only say it was something even more extreme than ‘world drift’… You did not see it with your own eyes, so it is hard for you to imagine how terrifying that collision was. It was the destruction and remolding of all things. Everything in the mortal world turned, in a very short time, into a dark, chaotic ‘primordial soup’. It looked… just like Subspace. And the worlds involved in that ‘collision’ were definitely not just two. There might

have been dozens, even hundreds of worlds crashing together at the same time. Atlantis's memory is only a corner of that Great Annihilation…"

Rune did his best to describe how he had felt when he saw that scene, and the ideas that followed. While he spoke, the towering Frem stayed silent and thoughtful. After a long time, this Senkin Pope, who looked like a small giant, suddenly spoke: "Are you sure… that giant who traveled with Miss Vanna was the Everburning Ember?"

"That is what all the clues point to," Rune said with a serious face and nodded. "That Chronicle Pillar is now on the Vanished. I have seen it with my own eyes."

He paused for a second, then added in an even more serious tone: "But I should warn you – if you want to take that thing away, it may not be easy…"

"I know," Frem shook his head before Rune could finish. "I will think very carefully about this… Right now, the most important thing is not that Chronicle Pillar, but information about my Lord. Or, to be strict, information about each 'Lord' we all serve."

He raised his head. Invisible pressure seemed to fill his gaze as he looked at each figure present.

Of course the others understood what that last sentence meant.

After all, in this world, the mortals closest to the Four Gods were them. They had long been able to sense what lay behind that hazy, awe-inspiring veil.

"…Our link with the Gods keeps getting weaker. The role of the Pilgrimage Ark is also fading," Banster said slowly. "When the ark was first built, I could almost hear my Lord's voice directly in the meditation room. But

after only these few years, that voice has already turned into a vague, muddled whisper."

"The Pilgrimage Ark is only an auxiliary anchor. It can only strengthen our link to the 'Lord'. It cannot truly slow decay," Rune slowly shook his head. "When we built these arks, we already knew this day would come sooner or later."

Banster fell silent. The tall, thin old man closed his eyes a little, as if he was quietly feeling and performing a Listening Rite. After a long while, he finally said softly: "Sometimes, I can almost smell them slowly rotting…"

The dark space grew quiet again. After a long time, Rune finally broke the silence in a low voice: "…Yes. We all can."

Banster turned his head and fixed his gaze on Helena in the darkness: "… The Deep Sea Church's fleet has been operating at the border for a long time. Have you made any progress?"

"The vanguard is still circling in that endless fog," Helena answered with a hint of frustration. "There are no routes or landmarks in the depths of the mist. The sea and sky both have a strange texture. Even if we use the Stargazing Room for navigation, the course error reaches an unacceptable level… We tried to build a few temporary lighthouses where the fog is thinner, but they only let us go a limited distance deeper into the mist… If we go farther, the fog swallows the lighthouses."

"Our fleets met the same problem," Frem added. "We entered the eternal Veil at the border through another gap. At first the fog was thin and the sea was still normal. But if we went just a little deeper, the mist suddenly grew thick. The lights we set up vanished in the fog as if something swallowed them out of thin air."

“This exploration has gone on for some time,” Rune said solemnly. “We have pulled patrol fleets from all over the world and massed them in the border seas. This has surely drawn the attention of many city-states. If we keep this up, it does not matter whether we ever find the ‘link point’ between the Gods and the mortal world. We will definitely stir up suspicion and fear among the people.”

None of the figures spoke for a moment. The Popes fell into their own thoughts. After several minutes, Helena suddenly said: “In all history, only one person truly went deep into the ‘border’ and came back alive from that fog.”

“…Yes. That is also the last thing I wanted to tell you this time,” Rune nodded slightly. “‘He’ is also willing to build closer ties with the Four Gods Church. It is not just about meeting one of us. He wants a truly deep ‘cooperative’ relationship.”

It was clearly a sensitive and hesitant topic. The other three figures did not speak at once, so Rune turned his eyes first to Helena: “You should support this. That Saint named Vanna has been living on that ship for a long time. You must have gotten a lot of information from her. I believe, like me, you know quite a bit about that ship’s current state and that captain’s condition.”

“Vanna… All right, just from the reports she sent back, that captain does seem trustworthy,” Helena rubbed her forehead, for some reason sounding a bit awkward. “Sometimes I even start to wonder whose Saint she really is. Lately she has been… a bit too trusting of that ‘captain’.”

“But at least you can be sure she is still faithful to her belief – otherwise you would not still hear her voice through the Storm Goddess’s divine blessing,” Rune laughed. “I met your Saint this time. We did not talk for long, but I could feel that she is… an honest and real person. Her judgment of that captain is worth trusting.”

“I also agree to build closer contact with that captain, including meeting him directly and inviting him to join our current operations,” Frem said from the side. “I do not have a Saint who was tricked onto that ship, but I trust Rune’s judgment. And in any case, I need to see that Chronicle Pillar with my own eyes…”

Helena and Rune spoke in unison: “Can you please stop bringing up ‘the Saint being kidnapped onto the ship’ every single time?!”

Frem spread his hands. “Fine, I will stop.”

Then, as if by agreement, all three of them turned their eyes to the only figure present who had not yet spoken.

Tall and thin, draped in a black robe, Banster felt a bit awkward under their stares and could not help frowning: “Why are you all looking at me?”

“Only your opinion is left,” Rune said seriously. “We all agree to build closer ties with that captain and to tell him about our operations in the border seas. What about you?”

Banster pressed his lips together. It was clear that his mind was still racing. After a long time, he sighed helplessly: “I need some time to make my bishops accept this.”

Helena looked surprised. “So you accept it personally?”

“What else? ” Banster spread his hands. “Personal feelings have to step aside at times like this – as long as ‘he’ does not take something from me again this time.”

Chapter 653: Leftover Problems

Order in Lightwind Harbor was recovering quickly. Even though this time the Nameless One's dream had spread much farther than the previous crises in Pland and Frostholm, its special nature meant that, once the "dream" faded, its effect on the Mortal Realm was actually the smallest.

Cities that had been swallowed returned to the Mortal Realm. Districts that had been covered and replaced by the nightmare were restored to how they had been. The flowing fire that had filled the sky in the Elder Gods' nightmare never burned anyone's head in reality. When a new day came, the border city had already gone back to its old look.

Of course, it was not true that the incident left Lightwind Harbor with no impact at all.

People still remembered the scene when the nightmare struck. Many citizens needed comfort, and the whole event needed a proper conclusion and explanation. Quite a number of people suffered short-term memory loss, hallucinations, and phantom sounds after they "woke up". These symptoms were not strong enough to cause supernatural corruption, but psychiatrists still had to step in. Even more ordinary people were troubled by fatigue, sleepiness, and sudden, unexplained heart palpitations. These were aftereffects left by the Elder Gods' nightmare draining and consuming their spirits, and no one yet knew how long it would take them to recover.

At 99 Crown Street in Lightwind Harbor, inside the Witch mansion, Duncan sat by the wide floor-to-ceiling window in the first-floor hall, looking at the street outside.

Steam Walkers belonging to the Academy were patrolling the street. Uniformed Knowledge Guards and constables were checking the districts for any leftover “dream residue”. Staff sent from the government office were knocking on doors one by one. They checked on the condition of each resident, wrote down those who needed help for “mental damage”, and took the more serious cases to nearby mental support rooms for treatment.

“…I just went to see Sara Mell. The situation in the city is better than we thought. There should not be much to worry about – my brother will definitely envy how Lightwind Harbor looks after this incident. Frostholm gave him a terrible headache back then.”

Lucretia stood beside Duncan as she spoke about what she had just checked outside.

“I also saw Master Taran Ael and that Truth Keeper who returned to the Mortal Realm. The first is in decent shape, just a bit drained and nervy. But to be honest, he is usually like that anyway. As long as his vital signs stay stable, we can call it a success…

“The other one was sent to the hospital. It is not really serious, just stomach trouble. Pouring down a whole bottle of Blood Raven Elixir put more strain on his digestive system than the mental damage did…”

Duncan listened to Lucy’s report half-heartedly, then said casually: “When we have time, we can visit that Truth Keeper. He knows about the Vanished’s activities at the border a hundred years ago. I want to talk with him about that.”

Lucretia nodded. Just then, a knock sounded from the entryway, cutting off her talk with Duncan.

Morris, who had been reading near the door, got up to open it. He exchanged a few words with the visitor, then the closing of the door echoed

through the hall.

“They are staff sent from the government office,” Morris walked over and said to Duncan and Lucretia. “They are gathering data on the mental state of each household, asking if anyone in this house needs psychological help.”

Duncan gave Lucretia a strange look. She spread her hands. “Not everyone knows about the Witch mansion, especially those rank-and-file clerks who were rushed here from other districts during the emergency. Their daily work already wears them out. They have no time to learn about a house full of ghost stories.”

Duncan shrugged and turned to Morris: “What did you tell him?”

“I told him everyone in this house is in good mental health, and that I am especially healthy,” Morris said offhandedly. “Then the Rahm emblem he was using to detect mental corruption suddenly burned up in his hand. I think no one will come to bother this house again.”

“A new ghost story,” Duncan turned his head and said to Lucretia.

“We dodged some needless social contact again,” Lucretia seemed in a very good mood. “That is a good thing.”

Duncan laughed, then looked out the window again. He quietly watched the street as it slowly regained its usual life and energy. Only after a while did he finally speak, thoughtful: “The incident in Lightwind Harbor is over… It is time to deal with some ‘leftover problems’.”

Lucretia blinked. “You mean…”

“Is Rabby still on that ship?”

“…I understand. I will go check on that ‘nest’ first.”

…

Richard felt a little cold.

Ever since the last time he pulled out of that “Nameless One’s dream”, he had often felt a chill in his body, as if the blood in his veins was thinning and stopping. It felt as if his body could no longer make enough heat. Adding another layer of clothes did not help. Even wrapping himself in blankets in his room did nothing.

He did not understand what was happening. He clearly had plenty of warm cotton, yet he could not stop the heat from leaking out of his body. This “abnormality” left him a bit restless and irritable.

He had asked Rabby about it. Rabby had not given him an answer, only told him to wait patiently.

Luckily, there were still many things to do here, so Richard could put his attention on other matters for the time being.

The ship was sailing across the vast sea, moving along a secret route far from all major shipping lanes. Under the Saint’s order, they had already left the so-called “civilized world” far behind and would reach a supply port near the border in a few days.

In the meantime, the believers on the ship were busy clearing away all the “arrangements” left from their last operation. They reset the runes in the assembly hall, sealed the Dream-Skull again, and readjusted the ship’s hidden state so its “scent” would be hidden even further.

Richard and several of his brothers in faith were checking the runes and the “sacred relic” on the lower deck.

“The Saint said these symbols can block the Suntists from sensing this ship,” Dumont muttered beside him. “…I hope they really work that well.”

“After all, we pulled out at the key moment. To those ‘allies’, that must look like betrayal,” Richard said casually. Then he frowned a little in doubt.

“But still… What happened that made the Saint end the operation so suddenly? Did the words of those Enders really carry that much weight?”

“I do not know,” Dumont shook his head. “But the Saint must have his own reasons. He can see the shadows in fate. I suppose he sensed some great danger hidden in that Nameless One’s dream…”

At that point, Dumont suddenly stopped. He quickly glanced around, then lowered his voice and leaned close to Richard’s ear: “Actually, I suddenly feel… this may have been a trap from the start. That so-called ‘Nameless One’s dream’ hid unimaginable danger. We were right to pull out when we did. Those Suntists might already be in trouble.”

Noticing how serious Dumont was, Richard also glanced around on instinct and whispered: “Why do you say that?”

“We backed out early some time ago,” Dumont raised his head and looked at the runes between the ceiling and the walls, which glowed faintly and ominously in the dark. “Yet that ‘Sun Spawn’ has not come here to the ship to hold us to account. To be honest, I do not believe runes meant to block ordinary supernatural beings can stop an offshoot of the Elder Gods.”

Richard froze for a second and finally started to react.

He should not have reacted this slowly. Most of the time, he was sharper than Dumont. But for some reason, his thoughts and reactions had become much slower than before.

It was as if only now, after Dumont’s reminder, he realized that the “Sun Spawn” might already have met with disaster.

“…You mean that Sun Spawn is already dead? Killed by the Nameless One’s dream?” Richard asked in a tense, uneasy whisper. “There should not be any power in the mortal world that can kill a Spawn. Could it be that dream…”

“It might also have been done by ‘his’ followers. Or by ‘him’ himself,” Dumont muttered. “You know who I mean.”

Richard shut his mouth at once and did not continue that topic.

They could not keep talking about it. Otherwise that ghost captain might turn his gaze here, drawn by their reckless words. The shadow of the Vanished would rise from the veil of night, and thick fog would sweep in and carry everyone away.

Everyone who sailed on the Boundless Sea had grown up hearing stories like that.

Even so, Richard could not help feeling a bit curious again.

He knew how powerful the Sun Spawn was. Even among all types of Spawn, they were the strongest. They were born directly from the black sea of the Sun’s fire, an essential offshoot of the Elder Gods. If the Mortal Realm had not been sealed and sheltered by the Four Gods, limiting the Sun Spawn so they could appear in the Mortal Realm only as projections, the full power of their bodies would have been enough to destroy a city-state in a short time. Power like that was hard to face, even for a mighty Saint.

Was that “ghost captain” really that strong?

Cold rose again from the depths of Richard’s heart. He shivered and quickly forced his wild thoughts under control, so his “thinking” would not draw some dangerous gaze from the darkness.

At the same time, he heard Dumont’s voice again in his ear.

“In any case, we left that whirlpool behind. A lot of people are still confused about it, but we are safe now.”

Richard stayed silent for a few seconds.

Icy cold spread through his heart. The blood in his veins seemed to have stopped flowing altogether. He felt cold, colder and colder.

He felt as if his body almost no longer produced any heat.

Even so, he still slowly nodded.

“Yes. No matter what, we are safe now.”

Chapter 654: Visit in the Shadows

In the spacious, ornate assembly hall, the roof and walls were covered with many reliefs and patterns related to the Abyssal Lord. On the high platform in the center, the twisted thing known as “the Saint” sat in silence.

A “crown” woven from pitch-black bones stood on the platform. Between the tangled nerves and blood vessels at the base of the crown were many half-open, half-closed eyes. A chilling brain lay in the center of the Bone Crown. It writhed slightly from time to time and let out low, muffled sounds.

The lower priests and ordinary cultists in the hall stayed quiet. They stood carefully and nervously in the corners, keeping their distance from the central platform. They did not even dare meet the Saint’s eyestalks, which were now in a dormant state. A dull, heavy mood hung over the place, as if even the air had frozen.

Everyone knew the Saint was in a foul mood—and it clearly had to do with the sudden end of the recent operation.

The order to end the operation had of course come from the Saint himself, but it was obvious this was not a result this Lord wanted to see—the outcome was not supposed to be like this.

This silence and pressure lasted for who knew how long. Then a voice suddenly sounded in the ears of every lower priest and ordinary cultist: “Leave.”

Everyone felt as if they had been granted amnesty. In almost the blink of an eye, the Annihilators gathered in the hall left the assembly through the various doors, and in the end only the upper priests beside the platform remained.

“Saint,” an upper priest in a black coat, his graying hair combed neatly back, turned to the platform and broke the silence: “We have received news from Morka and Siprode. The elves who fell into sleep and dissolution in the various city-states have begun to recover.”

“…The entrance to the dream has vanished, and the Dream-Skull no longer reacts to the ‘blood food’,” another upper priest said at once. “Judging from the current situation, the Nameless One’s dream has probably vanished completely—but even now, the Suntists still have not contacted us.”

“They will not contact us again,” a reply finally came from the Bone Crown on the platform. “The Sunspawn who led this operation has fallen. This loss is enough to plunge those followers into a long chaos… Having lost the Spawn that served as their core, the branch that cooperated with us will soon die out.”

The upper priests around the platform stirred at once. After a brief moment of shock, the gray-haired priest finally could not hold back: “Then the Sunspawn has fallen?! How did it die? Was it something deep inside the dream…”

“I do not know,” the Saint said. “I only saw its radiance suddenly go out at the end of its fate, and vast shadows spread out from the place where it went dark. Even now, those shadows are still spreading toward us.”

The upper priests looked at one another. After a short silence, one of them spoke hesitantly: “You mean… after the Sunspawn fell, the shadows that killed it are still chasing us?”

“A haze hangs over our fate,” the Saint said slowly. “It has yet to disperse.”

“We are already far from all city-states and main routes,” another upper priest said hesitantly. “And we have successfully avoided the patrol fleets of the four major churches along the border…”

Another priest spoke up at once: “I do not know what the Four Gods’ dogs have been doing lately. They gathered a large part of their fleets near the eastern border, which has greatly weakened the patrol forces in the other border seas. We passed through very smoothly. We should be able to return to the ‘Holy Land’ soon…”

Yet another priest agreed: “‘The Holy Land’ is shrouded in thick fog along the border, and our Lord’s divine blessing rests there. Even the Pilgrimage Ark of the Four Gods’ dogs cannot break through…”

The upper priests all began to speak, but the “Saint” on the platform stayed silent. Gradually, the voices around the platform faded, and the priests wisely shut their mouths.

“‘He’ is coming.”

After who knew how long, the Saint’s deep voice suddenly reached everyone’s ears.

With those few short words, it was as if an invisible cold wind swept through the entire hall. The wind carried a fear and dread that seemed almost infectious. Even the Oblivion priests, whose hearts were already as cold and hard as black iron, shivered without meaning to.

One upper priest understood the Saint’s meaning almost at once: “You mean… the Ghost who returned from Subspace…”

“How is that possible?! We have not had any dealings with ‘his’ followers since then…” another priest blurted out. “We withdrew from the Nameless

One’s dream before it changed any further. We should have already cut all ties with ‘him’…”

The Saint did not respond to those timid and useless voices, full of tension and fear, beside him. He only slowly raised the eyestalks around him. The eyeballs at the ends of those writhing tendrils swept over the hall, and then seemed to look through the walls, surveying the entire ship.

The haze in fate was reflected in his misshapen, swollen eyes. ghostly green flame burned in the shadows and had already begun to appear on the sea’s surface in the near future. He saw death and fear drawing near—in a not-so-distant time, most of the people on this ship would die.

As for the others, the misery in their fate was even worse than death.

He had already smelled, ahead of time, the scent of blood boiling in the flames, and heard the howls that would soon echo out. Yet more desperate than those coming deaths was that the shadows would keep spreading along this route. This ship was not the end, only a stopover for those shadows as they spread.

The Saint slowly withdrew his eyestalks.

In the limited future he could glimpse, he had carefully made many choices. Those choices had given him ever greater power and made this ship a symbol of the Lord’s will. But this time, he found that no matter what he chose, that haze followed closely behind in fate.

Whether it was ending the operation in the Nameless One’s dream ahead of time, changing the course of this “Holy Ship”, or sealing off the aura of the entire vessel, he could not shake off that terrible future.

Those shadows had surrounded him and everyone else. It even felt… as if they were already on this ship.

[Already on this ship?]

In the Bone Crown on the platform, the swollen, writhing brain suddenly froze for a moment. Then the living tissue around it slowly relaxed.

With that flash of understanding in his heart, the Saint noticed that the shadows everywhere had begun to weaken. On the sea not far away, the ghostly green flames that had risen from the darkness seemed to be slowly fading.

"…I have caught you," he muttered softly.

One upper priest reacted at once: "What have you discovered?"

"…Go and bring everyone who has entered the Nameless One's dream to the hall," the Saint said slowly. At the same time, some of his eyes watched as the haze shrouding the ship and the breath of death from the future kept weakening. "Especially anyone who has been in contact with that girl who once traveled with the Abyssal Hound… Richard, yes, bring him here… Do not startle him, do not let him grow wary. Use mental guidance to slowly draw him over."

The haze in the hall faded away completely. The sense of death coming from every part of the ship weakened sharply, and on the sea in the near future, the ghost-green flames sank back into the shadows.

The shadows really were on the ship. Once again, he had sensed that tiny "turning point" in fate—he had made the right choice and gained a good result.

One upper priest quickly left the assembly hall to carry out the Saint's order.

Then the Saint on the platform fell silent for a moment and gave another order: "Also, have the ship stop."

The haze in fate had scattered for now, yet a strange unease still lay in his heart. It seemed that things would not end so simply. That Ghost who had

returned from Subspace… might not be so easy to shake off.

Driven by necessary caution, the Saint decided to stay on this stretch of sea for now. Until he was sure all hidden dangers had been cleared away, he could not let this ship draw any closer to the Holy Land…

One minute later, Richard woke from a short and chaotic nightmare.

A cold wind from who knew where blew past his neck. Faint whispers, too quiet to make out, came from the corners of the room. The scenes from the nightmare had already faded from his mind, and he could not remember what he had just dreamed. He only felt a lingering, hangover-like flutter in his heart that slowly ebbed away, turning into a hazy impression as time passed.

“She is coming to visit…”

A vague voice sounded, as if it had risen up from inside his own mind.

Richard sat straight up in bed.

Soft, blurry whispers came from every corner of the room. The lamplight flickered on the wall not far away and cast many strange, mottled shadows, like crisscrossing mycelium, or like an invisible spiderweb covering the whole cabin.

“Time to welcome the Mistress… my lovely little doll…”

The small voice spoke softly again.

Richard blinked slowly. The numbness and dullness in his head seemed to fade bit by bit. He got out of bed and walked slowly to the cabinet at the side. After he opened it and rummaged inside for a while, he finally found what he needed.

It was a big roll of paper and several pencils.

These were the materials he used on normal days to practice tracing runes.

He looked quietly at these things for a few seconds, and a small smile finally appeared on Richard’s face. He hugged the paper and pencils to his chest and walked back to the bed. Without hesitating, he tossed his bedding and quilt onto the floor beside him and spread the big roll of paper directly over the flat bedboard.

“They are coming to find you… do not waste time.”

Richard softly repeated the whisper in his mind. With a smile at the corners of his mouth, he bent over the bed with a pencil in hand and began to draw with practiced ease.

The beautiful face of a lady appeared in his mind and slowly took shape on the paper.

Chapter 655: Invasion

The Mistress was coming, on this cold afternoon.

The soft rustle of the pencil sweeping over the paper filled the room. Lines of different depth and shade stretched and linked across the sheet as if they had a life of their own, slowly forming an image. Richard threw himself completely into this “welcome”, and a feeling of peace and expectation slowly filled his every thought.

Without him noticing, the cold faded away. The strange emptiness that had kept appearing in him lately also vanished. A smile appeared on his face, and there was only one thought left in his mind, only one image—she was about to arrive.

That beautiful lady, that Mistress he had never met. He admired her and joyfully looked forward to her visit… Would the Mistress like this place? Would she like how he had arranged everything? Would she smile and reward her little doll’s loyalty?

Rustle, rustle… The pencil moved lightly over the white paper. The Mistress’s gentle gaze came from the page, smiling as she looked at him.

A rush of excitement rose in him, but Richard’s hands were steadier than ever, and faster than ever. He did not even remember when he had gained such high skill in drawing, able to sketch these beautiful lines so quickly. In the end, he even picked up another pencil in his left hand. Both hands moved so fast that they seemed to leave faint afterimages…

But then footsteps suddenly came from the corridor. Thump, thump, thump, thump. They were as fast as a heartbeat and brought an annoying disturbance.

“They are coming for you, my lovely little doll…”

The light voice in his mind blew past like the wind, with a faint hiss hidden inside it.

That annoying, familiar cold feeling returned. Richard felt a wave of irritation rise in his heart. Someone was coming to bother him, to disrupt the moment when he and the Mistress would meet. They were almost at the door—but he had not finished drawing yet.

He sped up again. His hands danced over the paper, but the annoying footsteps arrived even sooner than he had thought.

The footsteps stopped at the door. Almost without a pause, someone knocked.

The pounding on the door felt as if it was hitting his heart. The sound echoed through the small room. At first it was still gentle, but in the blink of an eye it turned urgent.

“Richard, are you in there?” a voice came from outside the door. It sounded tense and awkwardly “polite”. “The Saint has called a meeting. Everyone is to go to the assembly hall.”

[Do not go. It is a trap.]

A warning rang in Richard’s mind at once. He could no longer tell if it was Rabby’s voice or just his own thoughts. He naturally ignored the voice at the door and kept pouring all of himself into the drawing in front of him.

The silence in the room led to even more frantic knocking. Bang, bang, bang—the sounds came quickly from the door. The person in the corridor

slapped the door with force and raised his voice: “Richard, we know you are in there. This meeting is very important. You are not still lazing in bed, are you?”

[Just a little more, just a little more.]

Richard frowned hard. His arms shook as if in a spasm. The Mistress seemed to wink at him. In the black-and-white drawing, those eyes were already as lively as a real creature’s.

But it was still not enough. He still had a few of the most important strokes left…

The knocking suddenly stopped. After a short pause came a heavy crash.

“Bang—crash!”

The flimsy wooden door was thrown open with force. Richard’s movements froze for just a moment—and in that brief instant, someone had already rushed into the room. A huge Abyssal Hound leaped from midair and slammed him to the floor.

[Did the last stroke fall in the right place?]

Richard struggled hard, trying to lift his head for a look, but the strength of the Abyssal Hound kept him from moving at all. He pushed against the floor with all his might, but only hoarse, strange grunts and growls came from his throat, and his head filled with furious anger—

He hated Abyssal Hounds. He hated these rough, violent monsters.

Someone grabbed his arm from the side and quickly tied it with rope. Then another person stuffed something into his mouth to keep him from using the power of spells. The people who had rushed into the room dragged Richard up from the floor, snatched his pencils away, and roughly pulled him toward the door.

The moment he left the room, Richard gave up resisting. His thoughts seemed to break off. His head felt stuffed with cotton. Like a walking corpse, he let several “comrades” hold him up by the arms and walked silently down the corridor.

“Wait,” one of the Annihilators holding Richard’s arm suddenly stopped. He looked up at another cultist walking beside them: “What was he doing when we rushed into the room just now?”

“It looked like he was drawing,” the other Annihilator said with a frown as he tried to remember. “There was a big sheet of paper spread on the bed, but I did not see what he was drawing.”

“…Something feels wrong. I will go back and take a look.”

The Annihilator who had spoken first said this quickly, then turned and ran back to the room they had just left. He stepped over the broken door and hurried to Richard’s bed, looking at the big sheet of paper spread over the board.

It was only a blank sheet of paper.

The Annihilator frowned. For some reason, he felt a touch of unease. Driven by that uneasy feeling, he lifted his head and quickly scanned the room—but found nothing.

The cultist let out a vague grunt in his throat. Out of caution, he bent down, picked up the blank sheet, rolled it up, and tucked it under his arm as he went back into the corridor.

“It is just a blank sheet,” he said to the others waiting in the corridor. “Let us go.”

A blank sheet.

Richard, whose shoulders were held down and whose movements were controlled by his “comrades”, raised his head a little slowly. With a confused look in his eyes, he glanced at the blank roll of paper that the somewhat familiar man across from him was showing. After staring at it in a daze for a while, a slight smile finally appeared on his face.

However, no one noticed his smile.

The messy footsteps faded away down the corridor.

More footsteps soon sounded in other parts of the ship.

The Annihilators who had received the Saint’s orders were already moving. These priests were now walking through long, dim corridors with freshly prepared lists in their hands. They hurriedly knocked on door after door and took every “comrade” who had once entered the Nameless One’s dream out of their rooms.

A tense mood began to spread through the whole ship. Some people sensed that something was off. Some noticed that the ship had stopped moving at some point. Those who had not been taken away secretly gathered in their rooms, nervously talking and guessing about what had happened. Those who had been taken were already arriving at the assembly hall one after another.

The Saint on the high platform in the center of the hall fell into a short daze. Long hours spent peeking at fate had left his mind tired. He suddenly felt a little nostalgic for the past, for the time when he still had a human body. That shell had been filthy and weak, but at least then he could lie comfortably on a bed, and his head had not been filled all the time with hidden whispers and chaotic screams…

He sank into this trance as his memories slowly wove themselves into a hazy veil. In the depths of that veil, it seemed as if an eternal peace was

beckoning to him.

That “peace” was a tall shadow burning with ghostly green flame.

The Saint woke with a start from this warning born of fate. Every nerve and vessel twitched and sent a burning pain through him.

“Saint,” a voice came from beside him. An upper priest was reporting: “Everyone you asked for has been brought here.”

The Saint raised his eyestalks. His gaze swept over the cultists gathered in the hall, some fearful, some confused.

Shadows so thick they could not be parted shrouded the entire hall.

The haze of fate blocked all his sight.

“Intruders have boarded the ship!”

…

Only after everyone had left did a faint, almost unnoticeable airflow suddenly stir in Richard’s room—and then a figure abruptly appeared beside the bed.

It was as if a “picture” that had been lying flat on some surface suddenly “flipped” and “stood up”. Lucretia’s figure rose out of the air.

She had been standing in front of that Annihilator the whole time, at the closest point less than half a meter away—she had just been turned sideways.

A picture had no thickness. Eyes in three-dimensional space could not see an “image” that lay parallel to their line of sight.

Lucretia let out a soft breath and looked at her own hands. Then she casually picked up the pencil that had been tossed aside and drew a few lines on her palm.

Then she waved her hand, and her “thin” figure changed from a flat image with no thickness into a normal, solid body.

She turned her head and glanced at the empty floor: “Rabby, I know you are in the room.”

Almost as soon as she finished speaking, a sharp voice like that of a little girl suddenly rang out in the room: “Ah, ah, ah! The Mistress is here! Rabby is coming out right away!”

With that high, childish voice, countless white bits of fluff suddenly appeared in every corner of the room!

From the shadows in the corners, the gaps in the furniture, the holes in the ceiling, the cracks in the floor—in every place where “fibers” could hide—countless tufts of cotton rushed out. It was as if the room itself was wildly pushing out foreign matter. In the blink of an eye, the cotton filled Lucretia’s view, then quickly gathered in the center of the room and slowly turned into a rabbit-shaped form made entirely of cotton balls, with no “skin” on the outside.

Next, the rabbit-shaped cotton mass started to “turn inside out”. Colorful cloth pieces crawled out from its belly and wrapped around it in an instant, turning it into a large, creepy-looking stuffed rabbit doll.

The scary doll swayed in place twice, then leaped at Lucretia in high spirits: “Rabby is here, Rabby is here! Welcome, welcome, a warm—”

“Be quiet,” Lucretia said coldly, catching the rabbit in midair with one hand. “Stay silent.”

Chapter 656: Longing for Cotton

The ship was very quiet. Apart from the gentle sound of broken waves slapping now and then through the open windows, the only noise in the cabin was the faint hum from the distant engine room and pipes. Most people seemed to have left this area. Even the ones who stayed were probably sitting carefully and quietly in their rooms at this time.

This quiet could almost give someone the illusion of being “safe”. If not for the faint smell of blood that drifted by from time to time, some reckless, clueless visitor might never guess that this was a lair occupied by a group of cultists.

But Lucretia knew that her “visit” had probably already been noticed by the master of this ship.

She could feel a wave of hostility aimed at her spreading across the ship. A powerful sense of perception was sweeping again and again through every corridor and every cabin.

She raised the small Conductor’s Baton in her hand and traced a few glowing symbols in the air. For the moment, they cut off the flow of her aura.

The rabbit Rabby stood carefully at her side. This creepy-looking doll was now nervously glancing around. After watching for a long time, it finally could not help but whisper: “Old Master didn’t come with you?”

Lucretia lowered her head and glanced at it: “You want to see him right now?”

The rabbit shivered at once: “No no no, Rabby is just a bit curious. Rabby doesn’t want to…”

“Father will come later, but I have to come first to help him clean up this filthy place.” Lucretia found the rabbit’s reaction amusing, but she did not keep teasing it. “He needs some living Annihilators for a certain… communication ritual. But if he descended here directly, I’m afraid there would be no survivors left.”

The stuffed rabbit listened half-understanding. After a while it suddenly blurted out: “Oh oh, Rabby remembers. The demons around ordinary Annihilators would be scared to death by Old Master, right?”

“…You do manage to remember a few useful things.”

“Rabby is very smart!” The stuffed rabbit instantly became proud. Then its tone changed, turning mysterious and eager to show off: “If that’s the case, Rabby has a suggestion…”

“Suggestion?”

“Maybe we only need to keep that ‘saint’ alive… From Rabby’s observation, that ‘saint’ has already eaten his symbiotic pact demons. He won’t die even if he sees Old Master…”

Lucretia raised her eyebrows.

…

Something had come aboard the ship. Shadows were spreading across the decks. A disturbing presence flashed in and out of perception. Some areas deep in the cabins were slowly slipping out of contact, and among the congregants moving about the ship… some of them were starting to act wrong.

In the bright, wide, and splendid assembly hall, Annihilators were gathering. More and more people were receiving the Saint's summons. These uneasy dark believers hurried in from all directions, whispering under the heavy air and carefully talking over the current situation.

Another dozen or so cultists were singled out and isolated. They were brought to the platform where the Saint stood. Ropes soaked with alchemical potions tied up each of them, and heavy collars to suppress symbiotic pact demons were fastened around their necks.

Several heavily armed priests stood not far away, clearly in charge of guarding these bound cultists.

The surrounding looks could not help but fall on those tied-up "companions". Whispers rose around them, guessing what kind of mistake these people had made to end up bound like this in front of the Saint.

Someone recognized that all the bound ones were "dreamwalking personnel" who had taken part in the Nameless One's Dream operation earlier. When people linked this with the fresh rumors that had just spread through the ship today, about the Nameless One's Dream and the Sunspawn, the hushed discussions grew even more tense and uneasy.

Richard only felt the whispering around him grow noisy and harsh.

The dull buzzing sounded like countless little files scraping his skull. It slowly turned into sharp noise and meaningless howls. He could no longer pick out the words in those sounds, nor understand their meaning. A cold feeling spread deeper and deeper through his veins, making him more and more irritable. What unsettled him even more… was that ever since a while ago, he could no longer hear that small but comforting voice in his mind.

[Where did Rabby go?]

He sluggishly raised his head and looked at Dumont, who was bound beside him. Dumont happened to lift his head as well and turned his eyes this way.

Dumont's gaze also held doubt and confusion. He opened his mouth toward Richard, but no words came out, as if something were stuck in his throat. Between his teeth, Richard could vaguely see some white fluff.

"You brought something onto the ship…"

The Saint's voice finally rang out from the platform. That chilling pressure locked straight onto Richard, Dumont, and the others.

"Where did you hide it?"

Among the dozen Annihilators who were tied up, a few trembled slightly, as if instinct still let them fear the Saint's pressure. The rest, however, stood completely still, as if they had lost all sense of danger and of anyone above them – as if the nerves and flesh that should have reacted to fear no longer existed inside those skins.

The black bones crisscrossing the Saint's body clicked and clacked. Each tap of bone on bone sounded like it could strike the soul itself. In that chain of clicks, Richard's tottering sanity seemed to recover a little. He finally remembered who he was, and then another doubt rose up – why was he tied?

He hesitantly lifted his head and looked toward the platform.

A harsh, commanding voice came from above: "What did you see in the Nameless One's Dream? What did you touch? What did you do after you returned?"

Richard's mind worked with great effort. In his dazed fog, the last spark of thought finally flared to life.

"It was the witch in the sea, that witch and her servant!"

He thought he shouted that.

In reality, he only jerked his mouth open. After a few rough, hoarse huffing sounds, he spat out a large clump of cotton in front of everyone.

More cotton still clogged his throat, so he could not form a single word.

The last spark faded. Richard lowered his head and stared blankly at the white fluff on the floor – cotton. Precious cotton.

“My cotton… my cotton… my cotton!”

A string of meaningless mutters came from his cotton-stuffed throat. Richard hurriedly threw himself forward, trying to snatch back that precious cotton. The ropes tied around his body threw him off balance. He almost fell flat, then twisted and writhed on the floor in a crazed, crooked posture, desperately trying to grab those damp clumps of cotton with his mouth.

Thud, thud.

Several other figures toppled over as well.

Dumont, Wesson, Sulock… all the ones who had once entered the Nameless One’s Dream with Richard dropped onto the floor. The deadly pull of the cotton was something they could not resist. They howled, muttered, and struggled, fighting with all their might over the cotton Richard had just spat out.

[Don’t steal my cotton! Don’t steal my cotton!]

Richard roared in his heart. He rammed his head hard against Dumont, pushing him aside, only for Wesson to clamp down on his ear with a fierce bite. They began to tear and bite each other for the sake of the cotton. All reason and feeling had faded, leaving only the instinct to snatch the cotton.

The hall burst into an uproar. Even the dark cultists whose hearts were as cold as iron could not stay calm in front of such a bizarre and horrifying

scene. They watched their dozen former “companions” thrash and writhe on the floor while still bound by ropes, watched them tear into each other while letting out mangled, broken howls. Cotton kept spurting from the wounds they bit open – like some living parasitic creature made of fibers.

“Execute them!” a shout rang down from the platform.

Bang bang bang.

At the Saint’s order, someone finally reacted. Several gunshots thundered through the hall. The armed priests serving as wardens started firing their large-caliber revolvers at Richard and the others. Right after that, others began calling on the power of their symbiotic pact demons, hurling magic bullets, lightning, and clouds of acid at their former “companions”, who were clearly no longer human.

Richard and Dumont’s bodies were torn apart with ease by these attacks. Their fragile skin split like old rags, ripping with harsh tearing sounds. Cotton billowed from their bodies in drifting clouds, with not a trace of blood or flesh.

In the blink of an eye, the dozen Annihilators parasitized by “cotton” lost their lives.

Yet after only a few seconds of silence, the cotton that had poured out of their bodies suddenly started wriggling again. The clumps began to devour and tear at each other, as if the obsession these people had for grabbing cotton still churned inside the fluff. As the cotton gnawed and ripped at itself, some light, drifting things rose from the pile.

They were spores, as fine as dust.

The spores billowed up like a thin mist and began to spread through the hall.

Even the dullest person felt a huge sense of danger and terror when they saw that hazy cloud of spores.

But the spores had only floated a short distance when they seemed to hit an invisible barrier. A powerful force quickly drove them back down into the cotton heap.

On the platform, the Saint opened his black bony cage that looked like a crown and a prison. Tendrils reached out from the giant brain within and waved in the air.

The drifting spores were all caught. A burst of fierce flame then flared into existence, burning up the pile of cotton that was still frantically writhing and heaving.

Chapter 657: Boarding

The cotton caught fire and in an instant turned into a great blaze. Along with the drifting spores, it burned down to ash. Then the flames quickly went out. Only now did the cultists gathered in the hall finally breathe out in relief.

That strange and horrifying scene, and those spores that so clearly meant to spread and infect, had filled every sane person with a sense of enormous danger.

But while the ordinary congregants relaxed a little, the gloomy pressure from the platform did not fade at all. The Saint lightly clicked his bony “crown” against itself. His eyestalks still swept uneasily over the hall and beyond. He knew the shadow hanging over this ship was still there. What he had just destroyed was only a sliver of that shadow that had seeped in many days ago. The true body of that sliver had already completed its invasion…

He had moved too slowly.

“Do not relax too soon. Uninvited guests have already come aboard,” his voice sank into every heart. “From now on, the whole ship is under hostile cultist invasion alert… Lentim, take people to search the entire ship and find the intruders. If anyone refuses to be searched or acts suspicious, kill them on the spot.

“Gomoro, take people to the engine room and seize control of the steam core and the main valves. The intruders may try to take the ship’s core…

take nitroglycerin with you.

“Persha, take your followers to the armory and arm all the ordinary congregants… let those mortal sailors take up weapons as well.

“Basmodon, take people to control the deck guns. The enemy may also attack from the sea.”

The Saint’s sudden string of orders snapped the Annihilators in the hall back to full alert less than a few seconds after they had relaxed. Everyone understood how serious things were. The priests who received orders quickly gathered their subordinates and hurried out of the hall.

The number of people in the hall dropped by about half at once, but many priests still stayed in the assembly space, forming layers of protection around the platform where the Saint stood.

After thinking rapidly for a while, the Saint raised his eyestalks again and looked at the high-ranking priest closest to him: “Eric, take people and execute all the sacrificial victims in the cages.”

The high-ranking priest named Eric froze: “Now?”

“I need fresh blood to strengthen myself. These intruders are far from ordinary. This is not the time to worry about squeezing out the greatest value,” the Saint said calmly. Giving execution orders was as natural to him as breathing. “We can capture new sacrificial victims later. For now, execute all the ones on the ship. Drain their blood and soak the deepest stone slabs of the cages. I need to gather strength and prepare for a final battle.”

“Yes, my Saint.”

Eric bowed his head at once. After accepting the order, he took several of his followers and quickly left the assembly hall.

His hurried steps carried him into the corridor that led deeper into the ship. He rushed past rows of tightly closed doors and down one connecting stairway after another toward the deeper, quieter cabins.

Thin, cool smoke had somehow seeped into the ship from somewhere. It made the corridor look faintly blurred.

“High priest,” one follower suddenly spoke, uneasy as he broke the silence, “this smoke isn’t right…”

“It really isn’t. Under normal conditions, how could there be so much smoke on the ship?” Eric frowned. Behind him, a shifting phantom floated in the air. Black chains stretched out from his spine, and at the end of those chains drifted a black creature like a shapeless lump of flesh. Many eyes opened across its surface, as if it were cautiously watching the surroundings. “…It’s too quiet.”

It was far too quiet. The whole corridor lay in stillness. No sound came from the nearby rooms. Only faint noise from some machine far away could be heard – distant and hazy, like it came from another world.

Where were the people he had sent out earlier to carry out orders? Wasn’t the whole ship supposed to be in the middle of a massive search?

Thin smoke drifted toward them from ahead. Eric suddenly twitched his nose. In the smoke, he smelled a familiar scent. Gunpowder.

Faint sounds suddenly came from some direction. Right after that, someone began giving orders from deep inside the smoke.

“Take your positions! Form up, load, aim -”

It sounded like a military commander shouting to his soldiers.

Eric turned his head in shock toward the source of the voice. With the help of his symbiotic pact “flesh aberrant” demon, he was the first to find it – a

squad of toy soldiers, as if carved from wood, was setting up formations on the floor at the far end of the corridor.

The soldiers were only palm-sized. Bright paints covered their bodies, and they wore uniforms like the musketeers and artillerymen of a past age. They ran back and forth across the floor. Some waved tiny flags as they dashed through the ranks, and some stood on higher spots blowing small trumpets. A commander stood on a block of wood dragged from who knew where, raising his command saber high as he gave his orders.

The musketeers were loading their “rifles”, which looked like matchsticks.

The other Annihilation Priests also noticed the toy soldiers gathering on the floor and preparing to “attack” in an oddly proper way. The scene was so strange that at first they could not even react. Some of them even felt it looked ridiculous and funny.

That feeling of humor lasted less than a second. In the next instant, everyone’s heart jolted in alarm. On the Boundless Sea, anything that looked wrong meant danger, even if it looked like a bunch of silly toy soldiers.

Eric suddenly remembered something. A legend about these toy soldiers flashed through his mind. He threw himself forward at once: “Down!”

His warning came a step too late. From the end of the smoke came the commander’s order: “Fire!”

Bang bang bang, bang bang bang.

Gunfire roared again and again in the corridor. Muzzle flashes tore through the smoke, and bullets screamed toward them. One Annihilator after another was riddled by the storm of bullets before they could even summon their symbiotic pact demons. One by one, they fell to the ground.

It was said that long ago, a foolish city-state had tried to challenge the Witch at sea, hoping to “kill the curse spreading over the Boundless Sea”.

An arrogant commander led his battle-hardened marines to surround the place where the Witch was staying for a time and launched an attack under cover of night.

Mist rolled in with the darkness. The attacking soldiers vanished one after another into the fog. When the Sun rose again, the Witch had turned them into one hundred and sixty-six toy soldiers.

To this day, that corps of toy soldiers was still imprisoned in the Witch’s shadows. When the Witch needed them, they would be freed for a short time and would wield the strength of a real army…

Blood was pouring from Eric’s body. The sharp pain was slowly turning into a numb cold. He lay on the floor, his mind helplessly recalling the story he had heard one day in the past. In the corner of his eye, he finally noticed odd things along the corridor – details he should have seen earlier, but for some reason had ignored.

Many oil paintings hung on both sides of the dim corridor.

Before this, those paintings had all shown the Abyssal Lord’s many avatar forms, along with images of demons and scenes from the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea.

Now the content of the paintings had changed.

Many familiar faces gazed sadly and painfully from the canvases at this smoke-filled corridor. Some of them… seemed as if they had still been slowly blinking up until a minute ago.

There was no response at all from the people who had been sent out.

The gloom crouched over the ship grew thicker and thicker, with no sign of fading.

On the platform in the center of the assembly hall, the Saint sank into a long silence, thinking, while anger and despair slowly brewed beneath the calm.

He realized he might have made a whole series of wrong choices.

All his earlier arrangements had not stopped the shadows from spreading. On the contrary, he was losing his “sense” of more and more sections of the ship.

A tense, uneasy mood was spreading through the hall.

The ordinary priests who had stayed behind here also began to notice that something was very wrong.

Those who had left the hall did not return, nor did any report come back. One internal phone line after another failed to connect. Even using Abyssal demons to sense, they still could not reach their “companions” in other areas. First they lost contact with the cargo hold and the water tanks. Then the cabins where the crew members lived. After that, even the nearby corridors…

It was as if the various compartments were slowly vanishing into a spreading darkness. Apart from this hall, the whole ship was being swallowed by something unseen.

Something formless was attacking this place.

Then something even more dangerous touched the ship. A huge, groundless terror fell over everyone’s minds.

There seemed to be movement in the corridor.

A cultist standing closest to the main doors heard faint crackling sounds from the hallway outside. He looked left and right, hesitated a moment, then

gathered his courage and stuck his head out to look.

Someone beside him noticed what he was doing and rushed over to grab his arm, trying to stop this reckless move.

They were too late.

The cultist who had stuck his head out suddenly went stiff. He swayed slightly in place, then “walked” backward in a stiff, doll-like way and stepped back into the hall. After a brief pause, he fell flat on his back.

His arms and legs shattered like fragile porcelain. At some point, his body had already turned into lifeless inorganic matter. As he fell, his head came free from the joint at his neck and rolled to the feet of the other cultists.

It was a crude doll’s head.

Cries of shock burst out at once. Then came the sounds of blades leaving their sheaths and weapons being cocked, rising and falling all around. Many Abyssal demons were summoned again. In that instant of panic and fear, the cultists in the hall scrambled to prepare for battle, while footsteps echoed in the corridor and drew closer and closer to the doors.

A silver-haired lady in a deep purple, luxurious court dress was the first to walk in. She had a doll-like, flawless face. Her posture was light and graceful. She simply walked straight into the assembly hall. The gathered Annihilators, Abyssal demons, and all those blades and guns around her were nothing in her eyes. She only looked around curiously. Her deep purple eyes were clear and bright, and deep inside them, it was as if countless invisible threads were reflected.

Another unusually tall figure followed her in.

This figure was like a nightmare that had seeped into the Mortal Realm and branded itself into everyone’s sight. Just by stepping into the hall, he had

already begun to scorch the sanity and nerves of more than half the Annihilators present.

Duncan lifted his head. In the ghostly green flames that were slowly spreading out around him, he gazed at the “Saint” on the platform.

“You and your ship are useful to me.”

Chapter 658:

ghostly green flame surged like a suddenly rising tide, flooding into the vast assembly hall in an instant and spreading toward every Abyssal Deep cultist present—it was as if this fire had been brewing and building on the ship for who knew how long, and when it rose it even roared like wind and thunder.

Shouts of alarm and furious roars erupted from all directions. Almost all the Abyssal demons reacted the moment the eerie green flame appeared. The weaker demons entered a runaway state on the spot, and even the stronger ones, driven by terror and instinct, refused to obey the orders of their symbiotic pact partners. Pitch-black Abyssal Deep rifts formed in the air above the hall. The cultists and priests being dragged away by the demons howled as they vanished into those runaway state rifts—the handful of “lucky” ones left behind had no choice but to hastily face the enemy who had suddenly barged in.

Chaotic gunshots rang out, and a few feeble spells fell toward where Duncan and Alice were standing.

But the flame stood like a wall. These weak attacks lost all strength before they could even get close. Bullets turned ghost-green in the fire and fell harmlessly to the floor. The missiles and acid conjured with demonic power turned into fresh flames in midair and whipped back the way they had come.

Alice stared wide-eyed at the thrilling scene. Strange and twisted demons filled the hall, along with cultists driven mad by terror, but Alice did not

feel afraid at all—she had followed the captain here to “watch the fun”, and things were indeed lively.

Very soon, though, she felt it was all a bit too noisy.

She looked toward the loudest part of the hall, frowned, and lifted her hand in a beckoning motion. Invisible threads drifted down into her palm. Before they left, the captain had told her that everyone in this hall was a cultist, and cultists did not count as people.

So, with this doll girl as the center, countless Annihilators suddenly went rigid and froze in place, then began turning into dolls one after another.

But just then, a low sound like drumbeats suddenly came from the center of the hall. A vast power burst out in an instant. It even briefly suppressed the spirit form fire spreading through the hall and brought Alice’s doll control to a halt.

The Saint on the dais finally moved. His eyestalks lifted high. Countless crisscrossing black bones clicked around the huge brain like folded limbs, then unfolded outward to stretch and brace themselves. The skeletal body that had looked like a bony cage quickly changed into a spider-like shape, and that horrifying brain now sat on the center of this bone spider’s back. It swayed, and from the swelling, writhing blood vessels came a constant “thump, thump” that sounded like both drumbeats and a heartbeat.

Duncan watched in some astonishment as the Saint rose from the platform, the bone spider clinging to the edge and sending a string of chaotic hissing noises toward them.

His expression was surprised—because he had not thought the thing on the platform could get any uglier.

Before he had time to make a comment, Duncan and Alice heard the terrified, despairing screams of Annihilation Priests dying all around the

hall.

They were the cultists who had withstood the first wave of demon runaway states, had luckily escaped the first blast of flame, and had barely survived Alice's doll transformation. As they howled, their bodies suddenly began to swell. Their human forms twisted in the blink of an eye into all sorts of horrifying shapes. Countless swelling, crawling traces writhed under their skin, as if another body had appeared inside them, out of control, trying to burst out of their flesh.

In the blink of an eye, the cultists' bodies ripped themselves apart and collapsed into piles of flesh on the floor. As they died, the demons tied to them through symbiotic pacts began to collapse and fall apart one after another.

But those collapsing demons did not simply vanish.

They turned into drifting black smoke and poured toward the air above the central dais.

"The Saint" raised his black bone limbs on the dais. The black smoke released by the Abyssal demons when they died rushed into the swelling, writhing brain and was greedily absorbed. His size doubled in the blink of an eye, and an even stronger aura leaked out of the brain, faintly forming a barrier around the dais like warped space.

"…You killed your last followers the first chance you got," Duncan said, looking at the dais with some surprise. "That really was unexpected."

"The weak are useless here… They would only become fuel for your flames or sacrifices to Anomaly 099," the Saint rasped from the dais. His bone limbs clicked as he slowly crawled down to the floor. "Better to turn them into my strength… I will fight you to the death in their place…"

Duncan could not be bothered to listen to his rambling. Halfway through, he raised his hand. The spirit form fire in the hall, which had been briefly suppressed, surged up again in an instant and spread toward the dais.

“You have dug up quite a bit of information,” he said casually. “But I still advise you to cooperate. My request is simple—I just want to talk to your ‘Lord’… and, if possible, I want to know where this ship is headed.”

“So that’s it… You really are dangerous to us, ‘Captain Duncan’,” the Saint said. He moved his long limbs forward, forcing back the fire’s corruption as he came. “All the more reason not to let you have your way… O Holy Lord, grant me Your divine blessing!”

The monstrous bone spider gave a low growl. Space around him seemed to twist for a moment. The spirit form flames that had almost set him alight were forced back again for an instant. At once he leaped high, hurling himself at Duncan, who commanded this sea of fire, as if ready to die together.

“The time for martyrdom has come!!”

This twisted, terrifying monster shouted in fanatical zeal. With shocking power he drove back all the flames spreading into the air. He was like a jet-black meteor, fearlessly crashing down toward the “Subspace Shadows” that filled the world with dread!

Duncan spread his hand toward the monster. The spirit form fire that had been forced back closed together in the air in the path of the falling body, ready to swallow the bone spider completely in the next instant.

But the Saint suddenly veered in midair.

At an almost impossible angle, the monster plunged straight down. With a deafening crash, he smashed through the hall floor, opening a huge hole. He

dropped straight into it and began furiously tearing through the decks below, disappearing from Duncan and Alice's sight in the blink of an eye.

Duncan: "…?"

Alice: "…?"

Things happened too fast. Never mind Alice's wooden head—even Duncan did not react in time.

After all, he had seen people die as martyrs before, and he had seen fanatical cultists too. But this was his first time seeing someone quit halfway through martyrdom. In a world where the Gods truly existed, could a zealot on the level of a Saint really leave his own "Lord" hanging?

Alice turned her head in confusion to glance at Duncan, then at the big hole in the center of the hall, its edges still wreathed in ghostly flame. At last she asked: "Did it run away?"

Run away? Out here on the vast Boundless Sea, on a ship already completely burned and corrupted by spirit flame, where could that "Saint" possibly run?

Duncan frowned. The thunderous sounds of decks and walls being torn apart and support structures snapping still came constantly from below. All at once, he understood.

"No, that guy isn't running… He's going to destroy the ship!"

Digging, digging, always downward. The engine room lay just ahead.

As fast as possible, as fast as possible, before that ghost captain reacted, before the roaring spirit form flames caught up to him.

He was almost at the bottom of the ship. Beyond the last layers of flooring and walls, past the piping zone… that was where the nitroglycerin he had ordered sent down earlier was stored.

As long as he detonated the nitroglycerin at the steam core, the chain reaction after the reactor boiler went into a runaway state would be enough to destroy the whole ship. Then… the “Holy Land” would be safe.

The huge, terrifying bone spider dug rapidly through the vast ship. Following his memory, he ripped open steel plates, pipes, and bulkheads along the way. This ship, built at great expense and once regarded by the Cult as a symbol of pride, was being quickly ruined by his digging, turned into a heap of irreparable scrap.

But the “Saint” did not hesitate at all. He only sped up, carving an ever faster path through the steel beast’s belly.

In his glimpses of fate, he had long since seen his own death, and the deaths of everyone else.

The weak congregants would die wailing, their flesh burning in the flames. He himself could not survive either, because the gloom had already covered every path. When you were still on the edge of the Shadows, changing course might have helped. But when the whole ship was already deep in endless darkness, choosing a different direction no longer mattered.

It was unwise to fight that ghost captain. In the clearest glimpse of fate, the Saint had seen himself defeated quickly and pointlessly.

Since the ending was fixed, he might as well do something bolder.

At the very least, he could not let this ship fall into that “captain’s” hands. He could not let anyone learn the secret of the “Holy Land”. Otherwise his sins would be unforgivable.

The last wall collapsed before him with a crash.

The cabin in the deep layers that housed the steam core finally appeared before him.

The bone spider almost stumbled as he burst into the space and landed on a platform ringed by pipes, valves, and control stations.

He raised the many eyestalks at the edge of his body and swept his gaze around the chamber.

As he had expected, no congregants were alive here. Only a few corpses lay on the open floor nearby, and around the control consoles and valves he could see twisted human-shaped Shadows “printed” onto the surfaces of the machinery.

The “Saint” did not “mourn” his fallen kin.

He had already found what he wanted. The explosives were stacked at the far end of the platform.

Chapter 659:

In the power section at the deepest part of the machinery compartment, all crew members and cultists who had once stood watch here were dead, but the massive steam core assembly still ran on without anyone at the controls.

The reactor boiler let out a low vibration. The pipes and valves around it gave soft hisses now and then under the automatic balancing system. Warning lights for the Boiling Gold catalyst blinked steadily, showing that pressure in the steam core was running high.

At the end of a steel platform a dozen meters from the steam core stood a huge copper column between floor and ceiling. Parts of its casing were cut away, revealing complex gears and linkages constantly turning inside. The precise machinery clacked in a continuous wave. Strips of paper were drawn into a slot at the edge of the column and spat out from another, then were transferred by teleportation to other backup devices or punch-card analyzers.

This expensive, precise Sorting Engine was automatically calculating parameters related to the next stage of the voyage and feeding the data to the machinery compartment. Part of its input and output came directly from the navigation station above. None of this could be allowed to fall into those Subspace Shadows' hands.

The great gloom in fate was gathering. A prophetic vision more frightening than death itself had come: that ghost captain had already reacted, and his wrath was descending on this place.

The huge bone spider hesitated no longer. He swung his long limbs, scuttled quickly up to the copper column, and drove a bone spike straight into the Sorting Engine’s main drive shaft.

The black bone spike was shrouded in a corrosive field. The protective casing of the drive shaft, tightly wrapped in thick copper and steel armor, gave way like paper. The spinning steel shaft inside shrieked in an instant, and the gears and linkages connected to the main shaft suffered a catastrophic breakdown, dragging the following punch-card machines and stored paper tapes into the mess.

The Sorting Engine and the later punch-card analyzers all drew power from the same main shaft. A single breakdown was enough to destroy the entire system. This was a deliberate “safety flaw”, meant so that in an emergency, the ship’s recent voyage records and its control center could be destroyed in the shortest possible time.

But that was not enough. Destroying the Sorting Engine alone would not stop that ghost captain.

As long as the ship could still sail, it could still carry that captain to the “Holy Land”.

What the “Saint” had to do was remove the steam core’s safety limits.

A steam core in active reaction was nearly indestructible. Its heavy shell isolated the Boiling Gold catalyst and reaction medium from the outside world. Even nitroglycerin might not be able to blow apart that sphere. He had to force an emergency shutdown first.

Now the shutdown conditions were met.

As the drive shaft of the Sorting Engine broke with a roar and the gear trains screamed, every mechanical device linked by gears, belts, and rods began to fail in a chain reaction. The steam core’s output flow almost

instantly passed the relief valve threshold. Lethal high-temperature, high-pressure steam filled the machinery compartment. The overpressure blast blew the steam core's safety pins, and with creaking noises, the reactor boiler's spherical shell began to descend.

The Boiling Gold catalyst dropped out of the core as the shell lowered, but the searing "fireball" still burned fiercely deep inside the reactor boiler. Its terrifying heat rushed with the flow toward the control platforms—a blast hot enough to steam a living person in an instant.

But to the "Saint", it was only a breeze.

He raised his bone limbs into the "breeze", seized the nearby barrels of nitroglycerin, and charged without hesitation toward the reaction vessel that was pouring out deadly heat and whose interior flames were surging.

[The time for martyrdom had come, the time for martyrdom had come… Blow everything here to pieces. The Holy Lord's work must not be disturbed by that evil spirit returned from Subspace…]

Flames roared in the reactor boiler. The runaway state blaze tottered on the Critical Threshold. A single barrel of nitroglycerin would be enough to give it a "push" at this point and blow the whole ship to pieces.

The Saint lifted the explosives high.

At almost the same moment, the flames inside the reactor boiler suddenly took on a layer of ghostly green light.

A terrifying face appeared inside the reactor boiler. In that storm of flame that was racing into a runaway state, Duncan's upper body slowly rose out of the steam core's torrent of fire. He bent down to stare at the bone spider holding the nitroglycerin barrel up close and asked in a thunderous voice: "You think this will work?"

"Die, Ghost!"

The bone spider roared and hurled the nitroglycerin at the reactor boiler.

A violent explosion followed. In a flash, the entire reaction vessel was caught up in a runaway state detonation of terrifying scale. Duncan’s flame avatar, not yet fully condensed, flickered in the blast, and the surrounding flames that had not yet been corrupted by spirit flame turned into the shock wave, sweeping everything in the compartment into the explosion.

The steam core exploded. The Boiling Gold catalyst triggered a chain reaction at the critical pressure. Amid terrifying thunder and wildly boiling heat waves, the whole ship began to tear apart with the machinery compartment at its center.

In the shock storm, the pitch-black bone spider stretched out his limbs, using every spike to cling desperately to anything nearby. His bone plates ignited in the heat. A shimmering glow spread over the swelling, writhing surface of his brain. His nerves burned away, and the blood in his brain boiled. He was close to death, but a strange, feverish excitement still stirred his mind.

He had succeeded in blowing up the steam core before that ghost captain fully took control of this place.

No one on this ship could survive, including himself—but at least the “Holy Land” was safe.

The lower hull beneath the machinery compartment began to split. Torrents of seawater boiled in the flames, then poured into the ship with a deafening roar.

The “Saint” folded his badly burned eyestalks and quietly waited for death to come.

But death did not come.

At some point, everything around him became quiet.

After a moment of hesitation and confusion, the dying bone spider slowly raised the eyestalks around his brain again. In his blurred, dim vision, burned by heat, he saw a bizarre scene.

Every flame in the machinery compartment was suddenly tinged with ghostly green. The spirit form blaze froze in midair as if time itself had stopped. The shattered pieces of the ship froze as well. Even the surging seawater hung motionless where it was.

And in the midst of this frozen world hung the blown-apart steam core. Its fragments still floated in midair, and droplets of molten steel spread out like a strange, dazzling flower.

A tall figure descended from the exploding fire of the steam core. In the frozen machinery compartment, Duncan stepped out of the flames and walked up to the bone spider.

He brushed aside the floating molten metal beside him and ordered the frozen flames blocking his view to move away. He regarded the “Saint” with a calm gaze.

This “Annihilation Priest”, whose body no longer showed anything human, was still alive. After facing the steam core’s massive explosion at point-blank range, after enduring a blast hot enough to vaporize steel, this monster was only badly burned.

And in their brief clash earlier, this creature had quickly judged the situation and unhesitatingly chosen the higher-success “blow up the ship” plan. That kind of quick, sensitive decision-making was almost like a kind of Foresight.

Very strong, very smart, and possessed of extremely strange power.

But to Duncan, something else mattered more—

As Rabby had said, this Annihilation Priest had already “eaten” his symbiotic pact demons. That erased his greatest weakness as an Annihilator: he would not die from the death or runaway state of his symbiotic pact demons.

That made him a bit more “durable”.

Of course, it was obvious that, if this Annihilator was to be useful, he had to heal first. In this weakened state, he could never withstand the pressure of establishing contact with the Abyssal Lord.

For now, Duncan cared more about another matter.

“I’ve heard this ship has a supply port you call the ‘Holy Land’,” he said, lowering his head and fixing his gaze on the bone spider’s many eyes. “Where is it?”

The feeble bone spider trembled slightly. Some of his limbs struggled up, then quickly fell again. A hoarse, muffled voice came from deep within the grotesque tangle of flesh: “Give up… You will never find it… I have destroyed all navigation records and control devices. Besides that, the Holy Land’s position existed only in my brain—and just now, I destroyed that part of my memory. Even if the Four Gods themselves came, you would not find that route…”

But to the “Saint’s” surprise, the ghost captain before him did not show the slightest displeasure at this answer.

Duncan only shook his head with a hint of regret.

“It’s fine. It won’t take that much effort.”

In a vague sense, the Saint suddenly felt something. He struggled violently with his bone limbs, and his badly damaged eyestalks turned one after another toward the figure standing in the flames: “What… what are you going to do?!”

Duncan did not answer. He only turned his head to look at the frozen flames in the air, the ship’s shattered compartments in the distance, and the surging seawater beyond the broken hull.

The ship was torn so badly that, through the broken upper decks, he could faintly see the sky between the frozen flames.

“This ship is good. What a pity.”

He sighed softly, then turned to the steam core that had been blown completely to pieces. He reached out to gently touch the ball of fire frozen in midair.

This flame had once been the ship’s heart.

Now, it needed to beat again.

The ghostly green flame began to ripple, and a low, strange rumble rose from every inch of the ship. As the shaking grew stronger, the powerless, broken vessel seemed to slowly “come alive”, struggling as it began to pick up speed.

Duncan leaned close to the light of the fire and gave the awakened ship an order—

“Go home.”

And so the great ship changed course and set out on the homeward route.

Chapter 660: Capture and Endgame

The skeletal spider let out a string of chaotic, piercing noises. It was a howl full of intense mental corruption, the roar of a Monster teetering on the edge of a runaway state. The anger in it almost turned solid. Yet that almost solid fury could not affect the ship beneath it, a ship that had just come alive and was now setting out on its way home.

Even badly wounded, even with his senses in chaos, the Saint could still feel the ship under his feet accelerating in a certain direction. He could feel the abnormal trembling coming from the hull. The steam core was completely destroyed, yet the propellers were slowly speeding up. The navigation and linkage systems were gone, yet the ship itself still knew the way home.

The torn hull pieces still floated not far away. Between the shattered fragments, ghostly green flame burned quietly like the Veil. It kept out the icy seawater and also cut off all hope.

The steel behemoth that he had personally blown apart was now sailing toward the Holy Land in the posture of a broken corpse.

Behind the skeletal spider, from that swollen, horrifying giant brain, came a strange pounding sound, like heavy drums. Its blood vessels swelled and writhed violently, as if something glowing was brewing inside. A mad, destructive aura suddenly began to rise.

But just as this Annihilation priest was about to use his own body as raw material and set off a world-shaking self-destruction, he suddenly found he had lost control of his body.

A weird stiffness hit him all at once. He felt every limb and eyestalk turn in an instant into something hard, like stone or ceramic, fused into solid pieces. Then it felt as though an irresistible force descended on those stiff limbs and pulled them outward, fixing them in place.

Terror spread from the depths of his mind. The Saint pushed himself to the limit to move one eyestalk that was still intact and turned that eye in another direction.

There, a beautiful Doll with silver hair and a dark purple court dress stood quietly in the flames. She raised her hand slightly, as if she was controlling invisible threads. In those faint truths refracted by fate, the Saint saw vague, transparent strands twining between the girl's fingers.

"Anomaly… 099…" A furious and terrified voice came from within his body.

"You need to calm down." Alice tilted her head a little and looked very seriously at the ugly skeletal spider. "Your threads were all tangled. I helped straighten them out."

The skeletal spider trembled, then finally lost consciousness. In the very last second before his body completed its Doll transformation, Alice let go of the invisible threads in her hand.

She still remembered that the captain needed this one alive.

Duncan gave Alice a somewhat surprised look, then glanced at the skeletal spider, which had completely lost consciousness. He asked curiously: "It has threads too?"

“Yes.” Alice nodded. “They’re just a bit messier than an ordinary person’s, but you can still sort them out.”

Duncan frowned slightly, a thoughtful look on his face.

Just then, a gust of wind blew into the engine room, carrying with it many bright, colored paper scraps. The paper gathered at the far end of the platform, more than ten meters from Duncan, and formed the figure of Lucretia.

At a glance, Lucretia saw the skeletal spider lying motionless on the platform. Then she noticed the completely ruined steam core and the shattered pillars of the Sorting Engine not far away, as well as the countless flames and fragments frozen in midair as if time and space had stopped.

Duncan stood at the center of it all. He nodded to Lucretia. “It’s all taken care of here.”

“…I heard a huge explosion from the lower decks, and I saw massive flames and torn metal flying from the stern…” Lucretia looked a bit dazed. She stared blankly at the unbelievable scene in the engine room for a long moment before she went on. “…Did you restore its power?”

“It will return on its own to its home port, though it may take some time.” Duncan waved his hand and looked around at the wreckage with some regret. “What a pity. I was quite interested in that Sorting Engine, and now it’s been blown to pieces.”

As he spoke, he shook his head, then raised his hand and pointed at the Saint lying on the platform.

“Take it away. This thing is badly injured. I want it to recover in the shortest time possible. It doesn’t have to be fully healed. I just need its mind and vital signs stable. I need it to open the door to the Abyssal Deep in the Deep Sea.”

“…Oh, all right, Dad.” Lucretia finally snapped out of her daze. She hurried a few steps forward and raised the Conductor’s Baton in her hand. With a faint look of distaste, she lightly tapped one of the skeletal spider’s legs with the tip.

A shadow suddenly burst from the tip of the Conductor’s Baton. It was like something sealed inside the staff. Duncan only saw its vague, ferocious outline flash through the air. Then the shadow swelled and solidified into a huge, horrifying mouth that looked like an abstract sketch. It swallowed the skeletal spider in one bite, made a hard gulping motion in the air, and then quickly sank back into the Conductor’s Baton.

Lucretia put the Conductor’s Baton away with a face full of disgust.

“…Your spells are all very handy,” Duncan said, watching Lucretia’s actions with a slightly strange expression. There was a trace of emotion in his tone. “The way you ‘summoned’ me this time was quite good too.”

“I hope it met your expectations.” Lucretia’s face brightened with a smile. “After I listened to you talk about the avatar form you use and the rules of the beacon that lets you Teleport between Avatars, I kept thinking about this problem. I’m glad it was useful in the end.”

Duncan nodded slightly.

He had come to this ship in his true body. At first, he had considered sending only a portion of his power as a projection. But after he learned the situation aboard, it was clear that Teleporting his powerful true body here was a more reliable choice.

However, this kind of teleportation needed a beacon, something AI could use for navigation. The mirror ritual he usually used was not enough, and the temporary bodies of the Annihilators could not withstand it. There were indeed other “things” on this ship that could be turned into beacons, but the

only ones left were the innocent sacrificial victims locked in cages by the cultists.

After all, outside the Vanished, a “beacon” was a body to be possessed.

Turning the ship’s innocent sacrificial victims into beacons clearly went against Duncan’s principles.

Thankfully, Lucretia had used her wits to solve the problem. She had made an artificial beacon in advance, something that could hold Duncan’s power when it descended.

She carried that beacon, used Rabby to control the cultists running the summoning ritual, and teleported to the ship ahead of time. Then she used the power of the artificial beacon to summon Duncan’s true body as well. From the look of it now, this whole Chain-Summoning process worked very well.

Duncan lowered his head and looked at his own hands.

The body he wore now was attached to the artificial beacon that Lucretia had made. That beacon sat inside him and was running in perfect condition.

“This beacon test went very smoothly.” Duncan raised his head and said to Lucretia, “If it can stay stable for a long time, you should carry one around from now on. Once you run into danger, I can come to your side at once. It’s more convenient than the mirror ritual.”

Lucretia froze for a second, as if she had not expected that. Then a slow smile curved her lips.

“Then I’ll send one to Big Brother too…”

“Frostholm already has one of my avatar forms.” Duncan gave her a sidelong glance. “He even went to the cemetery to visit me this morning. He doesn’t need your artificial beacon.”

Lucretia immediately looked a bit disappointed. “…Oh.”

“…Stop thinking about making trouble for your brother all the time.”

“Oh.”

Duncan shook his head helplessly.

“How are the sacrificial victims on the ship?”

“Rabby and I have already found them.” When it came to business, Lucretia quickly adjusted her expression. “The good news is, the place where they were held is in the bottom hold of the front half of the ship. The explosion in the engine room did not reach that far before you suppressed it, so no one died in the blast or the fire. The bad news is… their condition is very bad. Very, very bad. Some of them were already dead in their cells before we got there. Long sea voyages are boring, and those cultists used torturing the sacrificial victims as a way to pass the time. They even killed sacrificial victims who had lost their value as ‘blood food’ just for fun…”

She stopped and carefully watched Duncan’s face, which had grown dark as night.

“…But don’t worry. I will do everything I can to save those who are still alive. Even if they are on the verge of death, I can pull them back. It’s just that I can’t say anything about their mental state. That will need a more professional psychiatrist.”

“Mm.” Duncan nodded lightly. The grim look on his face eased a little. He exhaled, thought for a moment, and then asked, “Have you found the ‘Dream-Skull’?”

“We’re still looking.” Lucretia answered at once. “It is a precious but dangerous sealed object. It should be hidden in the best-defended and most secret place on the whole ship. I have already sent out my toy soldiers and

shadow servants. They are searching every cabin from top to bottom. They should find it soon."

Alice had been standing nearby, listening curiously for a long time. She finally caught up with the thread of the talk and suddenly spoke up with a worried tone: "What if it already got blown up…"

"It shouldn't have." Lucretia shook her head. "The Dream-Skull is a sealed object with a tendency toward animation and corruption. You can't put something like that too close to the steam core, or it might drive the machines mad. Even that bunch of cultists should know at least that much."

"Mm…" Duncan nodded slightly as he listened to Lucretia's analysis. Then his tone turned a bit odd. "But honestly, what to do with it once we get it back is another problem… I don't know if keeping it next to Goathead will be good for him."

Lucretia thought for a moment. "…The First Mate has a broad heart. I think it will be fine."

"Forget it. We'll talk about it after we find it." Duncan waved his hand. "For now, take me to see how those sacrificial victims are doing."

Chapter 661: The Home Port's Bearing

The cages were in a cabin that had been specially reinforced. The narrow, damp, stuffy space was divided by iron bars into more than a dozen large and small cages. The sacrificial victims had been imprisoned inside them.

Going into a place like this never brought any good feeling. Even Lucretia frowned slightly when she stepped into this prison.

By the time Duncan arrived, the victims who had originally been locked in the cages had already been moved to an open space at the far end of the cabin. The environment there was a bit better, and it was right next to a vent. It looked like a place where the warden stopped for short rests.

The air was filled with a foul smell, the stench of blood and rotting flesh. Dirty bloodstains marked the cages on both sides, some of them clearly very fresh. Various "tools" for bleeding, skinning, and piercing hung on the walls and pillars between the cages, giving off an unpleasant aura.

Duncan walked past these iron cages and instruments of torture. Led by Lucretia, he went straight to the end of the cabin to look at the survivors.

His arrival caused a commotion. A tall figure wreathed in spirit form flames stepped into the cabin, looking like an Evil Spirit that had broken into the Mortal Realm. The surviving sacrificial victims cried out at once and tried to shrink back. Yet they were too weak, unable even to stand and run. After a brief struggle, they could only lean against each other and squeeze into the corner, staring in fear at the "Evil Spirit" standing in the ghostly flames.

Duncan could only feel helpless about it. Of course he knew that he looked rather frightening right now. But he had “descended” onto this ship by relying on the artificial beacon that Lucretia had made. To stay in tune with the beacon, he had to maintain this spirit form body.

Soon, though, he noticed that not everyone had backed away in panic. One thin, small figure still remained where she was.

It was a girl who looked about seven or eight. Her clothes were torn, and her body was covered in wounds. Her face was smeared with blood. She sat quietly on the floor, looking up at Duncan and Lucretia. There was no clear emotion in her eyes.

Duncan felt a bit curious. He bent down in front of the child and looked into her eyes. “You’re not afraid?”

But the child did not react at all. Her gaze did not change either. She only stared blankly at Duncan, the ghostly green flames reflected in her confused eyes.

“I already asked.” Lucretia walked up beside them and spoke softly behind Duncan. “The cultists carried out a sacrificial rite on her parents right in front of this child. She has been like this ever since. That was a long time ago. She has been on this ship for a year.”

The Sea Witch paused, then went on: “…Children are special and rare ritual materials, especially for Annihilators. They keep children for their most important rituals.”

Duncan did not speak. His back was to Lucretia, so she could not see his expression after he heard this. Only ghostly green flame spread slowly through the depths of the cabin and began to crackle.

After a few seconds, Duncan reached out. His unreal spirit form hand rested on the child’s head, and he gently ruffled her hair.

“You will get better.”

Then Duncan straightened and glanced back. “Lucy, did you bring any candy?”

Lucretia blinked, then shook her head with a hint of guilt. “…No. I only brought some potions I use every day… Ah, I have some biscuits. Biscuits Lunie baked.”

As she spoke, she quickly pulled a few biscuits from her clothes. After looking up at her father, she stepped forward and put the biscuits into the child’s hands.

The little girl finally showed some reaction. She lowered her head to look at the food, then began to stuff it into her mouth by instinct. She ate quietly and quickly.

“Eating” was one of the few instincts she still had after “living” on this ship for a year.

After a while, two more withered, skinny figures crawled from the corner. Almost wriggling like worms, they crept over to Duncan and kissed the floor where he had just stepped.

Duncan lifted his head. Under his gaze, he looked at all the eyes in the dark corners, eyes filled with fear, confusion, or numbness. After a long time, he suddenly asked in a low voice: “Are there any cultists still alive on this ship?”

“They have all been killed.” Lucretia answered at once. “By your standards, aside from that Saint, no other Annihilator needed to be kept alive.”

“Good.” Duncan nodded slowly, then gave another order. “Send your servants to get food and water. Let these people recover a bit of strength first.”

Lucretia bowed her head. “All right.”

Then Duncan and Lucretia left that deeply unpleasant cabin. A moment later, they stood on the deck.

The “living” ship was still sailing in a straight line toward the Holy Land, moving across the sea in a horrifying, broken posture.

The entire rear half of the ship was almost torn to pieces. Huge cracks ran across the deck and hull. The explosion had left the shattered wreckage blooming outward in a terrifying pattern. Countless scattered fragments still hung where they had been at the moment of the blast, frozen in place relative to the ship. ghostly green flame burned quietly between all the fragments and fractures. It seemed to have fixed the whole ship in the instant of its destruction, branding that ruin onto it forever.

Vision 001 was slowly climbing toward its high point in the sky. Yet layers of fog had appeared on the nearby sea. The mist spread up from the ship and then gathered and wove together overhead. sunlight filtered through the mist in a weak and hazy way.

“…The aura of the Spirit Realm is rising. The ‘changes’ on this ship seem to have attracted the shadows wandering near the edge of the Mortal Realm.” Lucretia looked at the strange fog on the sea around them, a slight frown on her face. “This is a ‘wild sea region’ far from the main routes. The space around here is not as stable as it is near the city-states.”

“Will they cause trouble?”

“No.” Lucretia thought for a moment and shook her head. “Your power rules this ship. Those shadows won’t dare come too close. But the ordinary people aboard do need to be moved as soon as possible. Their mental state is already very bad. In a Spirit Realm environment, they might undergo a transformation.”

“Later I’ll have AI open a gate and help you Teleport them to Lightwind Harbor.” Duncan nodded. Then he suddenly asked, “Besides that, can you tell where this ship is heading?”

“The Stargazing Room was destroyed in the explosion, so we can’t pinpoint our exact position.” Lucretia answered. “But based on Rabby’s rough sense in the Spirit Realm, it should be heading toward the southeastern ‘border’.”

Duncan turned his head at once. “The border?”

“Yes.” Lucretia nodded. “I was as surprised as you. But in this direction, there are no other city-states or small islands. This ship is also ‘returning home’ in a straight line at your command. So its only possible destination… is the Veil at the border.”

The “home port” of this ship was actually in the direction of the border?

Could there be some unexplored island near the mist known as the Eternal Veil? Or… was this ship’s destination simply that very mist?

Lucretia seemed to see the shock and doubt in Duncan’s heart. She spoke up on her own. “The Church of the Four Gods has always kept several standing fleets patrolling the borders of the civilized world. Near the Veil, every island has been charted, and every foothold is under the Church’s control. So the only explanation is that this ship’s destination lies inside the mist, a place outside the Church’s sight.”

Duncan frowned deeply. It still felt unbelievable. “…They opened a secret route right under the Church’s nose?”

“Crossing the border and slipping through the Church’s blockade or around the Ark fleets’ patrol routes is not that hard.” Lucretia explained. “The border is so long. The Church can’t keep every inch of the Veil under its gaze. The patrol fleets were never meant to stop every illegal ship passing by. From the very beginning, their main purpose has been to watch the

changes in the border fog. Between those fleets, there is enough time and space for several ‘secret routes’ to exist. If I wanted to, I could reach the Eternal Veil without anyone noticing.”

She paused for a moment, and her tone grew especially serious.

“So compared to the existence of a ‘secret route’, the truly unbelievable thing is that this ship’s ‘home port’ might be inside that mist.”

Duncan understood what Lucretia meant.

In the vast seas of the border, it was not difficult to avoid the Church’s eyes. The truly hard part was to survive in that fog after doing so.

The giant wall of fog called the Eternal Veil was the end of the civilized world. Ever since the age of the Deep Sea, “stay away from that thick fog” had always been an iron rule in every adventurer’s heart.

As Lucretia talked with him about this now, there was another layer of complex feeling in her voice. A hundred years ago, the trouble with the Vanished had happened after Duncan Abnomar insisted on crossing that very wall of fog.

What was inside that fog? Did it have an end? Was there a wider world beyond it? What had the Vanished found in the depths of that fog a hundred years ago?

These questions had long weighed on the hearts of Duncan Abnomar’s two children. Even now, even after “Duncan” and the Vanished had both “returned” to this world, those questions still hung over Lucretia like a dark cloud.

In a way, that cloud even hung over the whole world.

A heavy and complex look slowly appeared in Duncan’s eyes. He turned, walked to the very front of the bow deck, placed both hands on the rail, and

stared at the distant sea where thin mist spread over the water.

Now, this ship was sailing at full speed toward that cloud.

Chapter 662: Border Intelligence

Duncan gazed at the distant sea, lost in thought. Lucretia stood quietly behind him. The silence lasted for who knew how long, until Duncan finally broke it and said: “Tell me about the border.”

Lucretia took a step forward and said in a hesitant tone: “You…”

“I do not remember what happened back then,” Duncan said softly. “So I want to hear your view of the border. All these years, you have been active in the border region. As far as I know, you even risked entering that thick fog a few times… If we are destined to deal with that fog again, then at least I want to know what you understand about it.”

Lucretia’s eyes looked hesitant and complicated. She stared fixedly at Duncan’s back, as if she feared this figure would suddenly disappear into the wind again. Before today, Father had also spoken with her about the border, but their talks on this topic never went deep. She always chose to avoid it. Yet today… things seemed different.

After a few seconds, this “Sea Witch” finally spoke: “…I did enter that fog, but only at a very shallow level. Six nautical miles. That is my limit inside the mist. In theory, it should also be the limit of the Four Gods Church’s ships for monitoring in that area.”

“What is there?” Duncan asked curiously.

Lucretia thought for a moment and said: “Most of the sea there was calm, even calmer than other normal waters of the Boundless Sea. The surface was like a mirror. It clearly reflected the flag on the mast. There were no

waves at all. The ripples raised when a ship passed would smooth out in a very short time. The whole sea felt like some heavy, sticky substance that could not form ripples. But it was in fact sea water, and the sailing of the ship itself was not affected…"

"But that was only the case in the Calm Zone. Between those calm waters there were strange and irregular belts of turbulence. They would appear all of a sudden, with no prophetic omen. Even after they appeared, it was hard to see them with the naked eye. The fast moving water still looked calm on the surface. It swept past like some kind of cutting line. If a ship came too close by mistake, it would enter a runaway state. In the lighter cases, the ship would spin quickly and be carried by the current onto the wrong route. In the worse cases, it would capsize outright."

"And all of this could still be called the mild side of the mist. When it was not so mild… some very strange things would appear.

"Sometimes, things beyond understanding would suddenly appear in the fog, like huge blocks floating on the sea, or 'mountains' that stabbed straight up from the ocean like blades. But it was very hard to get close to these entities that surfaced from the mist, because very large scale anomalous phenomena in the sky would usually appear around them. Sometimes it was a storm. Sometimes it was a huge ring shaped current. Sometimes an entire stretch of sea water would even vanish into thin air, leaving a fault like a bottomless abyss below, terrifying beyond words…"

Lucretia stopped here. It seemed she was recalling things that left even a Sea Witch like her with lingering fear. After she took a moment to gather her thoughts, she went on:

"In the middle of this chaos, there were sometimes gains. For example, unknown 'materials' and 'objects' would appear together with the currents or storms. They were entities you could touch, catch, and store, and even

bring out of the mist. Some of them were very useful, such as Ever-Burning Grease, or crystals that could drive away mental corruption. The Explorer Association and the Truth Academy would pay a high price to buy these items and study their uses. But in general, the things collected from these border manifestations were random and one of a kind. There was no way to get them in a stable way…

“In even fewer cases, in the middle of these chaotic and dangerous phenomena, there would appear…”

She suddenly stopped, as if she was not sure she should go on.

Duncan could not help frowning: “Lucy, what did you see?”

“Only once. To this day I am still not sure whether it was real or just a hallucination from extreme exhaustion,” Lucretia said after hesitating for a long time. “It was a huge cylinder that suddenly rose out of the sea. The cylinder was pitch black. giant ring like structures surrounded it, also black, with no visible detail. It was the only mist entity I ever managed to approach. The waves around it were not too strong, and the Radiant Star could barely hold its own there. I came to the foot of that cylinder. I even brought the ship alongside it and touched its surface with my hand… and then, I heard it speak to me.”

Lucretia raised her hand and pointed at her own head: “The voice roared inside my mind. It was a language I did not know, yet I could understand its meaning directly. It kept repeating one sentence: ‘Curvature Engine activated… we are leaving danger. Curvature Engine activated… we are leaving danger…’”

She lifted her head, saw the subtle change on Duncan’s face, and could not help asking: “Do you know what that sentence means?”

The moment Duncan heard the sentence Lucretia mentioned, he frowned. The words “Curvature Engine” raised a huge wave in his heart. He instantly thought of the ship that had crashed in the Deep Sea era, the New Hope!

Lucretia had found the wreckage of that ship? It had fallen into the Eternal Veil?

“Can you find it again? Have you seen it again after that?” he asked quickly.

“I am afraid not,” Lucretia said. From Father’s attitude she could feel how important this was, but she could only shake her head in apology. “The things that appear in the border mist are random and short lived, like illusions you can touch. When their time is up, they vanish without a trace. So far, I have never run into the same entity twice in that mist.”

A wave of disappointment rose in Duncan’s heart, but he did not show much of it. “…Besides that sentence, did you find anything else?”

Lucretia thought hard and said, not very sure: “Other than that, it was the touch when I laid my hand on it. It was an extremely strange feeling. It felt hollow. There was no temperature and no hardness. I know this sounds odd, but at that time my fingers could not tell what kind of material I was touching at all, or even whether I was touching anything. In that instant, the sense of touch in my fingers seemed to vanish. Or maybe that thing… only kept part of its properties in the Mortal Realm, so I could not fully sense the parts that had disappeared…”

As she spoke, she sounded more and more unsure, as if she could not clearly put into words what she had felt then or what she was guessing now. In the end, she could only spread her hands in helplessness: “Can you understand what I am saying?”

Duncan, however, showed a thoughtful look. After he heard Lucretia describe all these bizarre and unbelievable things, what suddenly came to his mind was the brief shift in his own perception, or rather his sudden insight into the world, in the few seconds after he saw the truth of the Great Annihilation.

He still clearly remembered the “true” face of the world he had seen in that final moment.

Broken pieces of information had joined together into the current Deep Sea era. Incompatible fragments of the Old World had crashed into one another, fused and twisted, turning into things that looked nothing like what they had been, or melting into the boiling stew of information at the bottom of the world.

Then… what about the things that had never fully merged, or that could not be completely erased or corrupted by other things because of some special nature of their own?

Such things had to exist. When a collision on the scale of the universe took place, the chances of every event, from infinitely big to infinitely small, would all stack together. Anything could happen. Anything could also never happen. So those “lucky ones” or “unlucky ones” that were bound to remain even after a chance that small had to have some place to go…

Duncan guessed that most of them should be in Subspace. In that dark and chaotic space, there were many things that seemed to be Old World wreckage. Torn landmasses, pale one eyed giants, and vague shadows floating in the void. They should all be fragments that had not been fully erased.

But now it seemed that some of them had fallen in places outside Subspace.

The “entities” the Sea Witch had seen in the border mist were things like that.

Lucretia felt a bit uneasy. She saw the expressions on Duncan’s face keep changing, as if some pattern of thought she could not understand was slowly taking shape in Father’s mind. It gave her the same feeling she had had back then, when she had a premonition of seeing the Starry Sky.

But this time, she did not truly see starlight rise behind Father’s body.

“I am very interested in those ‘entities’ you saw in the border mist,” Duncan suddenly said, cutting off Lucretia’s wandering thoughts. “What about deeper in? You just said you can only go six nautical miles into the mist at most. What happens if you go farther?”

“You completely lose your sense of direction toward the civilized world,” Lucretia answered at once, suddenly brought back to herself. “In fact, as soon as you enter the Eternal Veil, all normal navigation tools stop working. Even when you look out from the stargazing room at the Abyssal Deep Starry Sky, you can only see a hazy blur of shadows. Only within six nautical miles can the radio still barely work, and the lighthouses or ritual braziers set up on the border of the mist can still guide a ship back. But once you cross that six mile threshold, all contact with the civilized world is completely cut off.

“I once went too far in and crossed that threshold. Even though I crossed it only a little, I almost lost myself in that fog forever. Going back the way you came is meaningless, because once the ship goes through a Boundary Crossing, the continuity of space and time around you seems to be broken. When your ship goes one step forward and then one step back, it will not return to where it was…”

Duncan listened and could not help frowning: “Then how did you get back?”

“I…” Lucretia opened her mouth, hesitated for quite a while, and then said softly with a strange look on her face: “I saw the shadow of the Vanished.”

Chapter 663: Alice’s Spoils

“You saw the shadow of the Vanished?!” Duncan did not hide his surprise at all.

“Yes,” Lucretia looked at Duncan and nodded in a tone that was a little hard to read. “After I had been lost in the fog for three days, I saw a silhouette that looked very, very much like the Vanished sail past in the distant mist. Wherever it passed, the thick fog seemed to thin for a short time and show the look of a normal sea. I… hesitated for a long time, but I had no other choice then, so I gathered my courage and sailed toward that silhouette. But just as the Radiant Star was about to come close, it suddenly vanished… and then I returned to normal waters.”

After Lucretia spoke, she looked at Duncan with a strange gaze for several seconds before adding: “That was in 1862. You had already fallen into Subspace for sixty-two years.”

Duncan was silent for a moment. He turned quietly to look at the distant sea to hide the change in his eyes and said calmly: “I do not remember that.”

“I know,” Lucretia nodded. “So I have always doubted whether what I saw was really the Vanished, or only a hallucination from exhaustion. Or perhaps… it was also some kind of special phenomenon of the border.

“That was my first and only time crossing the six mile limit. After that I never went in that deep again, and I never saw such a phantom again.”

Duncan said nothing. His thoughts rose and fell inside him.

From Lucretia’s account, he finally understood for the first time just how strange and dangerous that endless mist called the border of civilization, the Eternal Veil, really was. At the same time, countless guesses, and curiosity, rose in him about the unbelievable things that appeared in that mist.

It was clear that entering that mist carried huge risk. Even someone like Lucretia, a seasoned border scholar and explorer, had almost been lost forever in the Veil even with full preparations. And even in the relatively safe six mile Calm Zone, all kinds of strange and deadly entities and phenomena could claim an explorer’s life at any moment.

But those strange and dangerous entities were exactly what drew Duncan’s attention.

The shadow that seemed to be the remnant after the crash of the New Hope was only one of them. In that mist within six miles of the border, how many other remnants like the New Hope were there? Were they all the core residues left after different worlds were wiped out? What mechanism had left those residues behind until now? Those entities circled the whole Boundless Sea inside the mist. Then what lay outside that ring? What remnants were there?

Vaguely, Duncan had a feeling that these entities, which felt strangely hollow in Lucretia’s senses, might help him understand the deepest crisis of this world, and might even help him find a way out of the underlying corruption of all things…

A gaze from his side pulled Duncan out of his thoughts. He looked up and saw Lucretia standing quietly nearby, watching him. Her complicated eyes seemed to hold a faint worry.

“…You are going there again, are you not?”

Lucretia asked in a low voice.

“…This ship is sailing toward the border,” Duncan said, patting the handrail beside him. “Those Annihilators have a hideout in the border mist. One way or another, I will deal with it.”

“I do not mean this time. Those cultists will not hide very deep. Wiping out their lair may be easy for you. I mean after that,” Lucretia said as her gaze fell on Duncan’s eyes. “After you clear out that lair, your attention will turn to the mist, will it not? You will go to investigate the entities and manifestations I described to you, and even… go beyond the six mile mark.”

Her gaze brought a bit of pressure. For the first time, Duncan felt that the gaze of this Sea Witch was a little hard to face. But after a short silence, he still nodded: “If the situation calls for it, I will go.”

Lucretia pressed her lips together.

But she did not try to talk him out of it or stand in his way. She only spoke suddenly after a long silence: “Take me with you this time. My experience can help you.”

Duncan was a little surprised. He looked at the witch for a few seconds before he spoke softly: “…What if the end of the mist is Subspace?”

“Then I will need your experience.”

Duncan did not answer at once. He turned and silently gazed at the distant sea for quite a while before letting out a slight breath. “We will talk about it later. I do have this idea, but it is not yet time to go deep into the mist. At the very least, before that I must first destroy the cultists’ lair hidden on the border and make contact with the Four Gods Church.”

Lucretia nodded lightly.

Just then, the sound of footsteps and a strange clatter of metal came from not far away, cutting off their talk.

Duncan looked toward the sound and saw Alice strolling over in high spirits. The doll miss held a big wooden box in one arm, and in her other hand she carried a large bundle of kitchen knives, spatulas, and iron spoons she had scavenged from who knew where. She had strung them together with wire, and she walked over as happily and boldly as if she were bringing back spoils of war, making clanking noises all along the deck.

“Captain!” The silly doll came right up to Duncan, lifted the long string of “treasures” in her hand, and shook them in the air. “Look! I have my own spoils too!”

Duncan was still caught in the serious talk he had just had with Lucretia, and this excited, silly beauty shattered all his thoughts at once. He stared blankly at the string of things in Alice’s hand for quite a while before he finally reacted: “…You looted the kitchen?”

“Yes, yes,” Alice nodded again and again in small motions, her face full of pride. “Goathead said that after we take an enemy ship, we must raid the treasury at once and get enough spoils before it sinks. I just followed those toy soldiers and crawled all over the ship, and finally found the kitchen…”

She paused to think back and then said with some feeling: “This ship really is not very good. The things on it do not seem very smart. When I was collecting spoils, the things in the kitchen did not even fight back. I was all ready to have a battle with this kitchen knife…”

Lucretia stared in shock at the doll’s chatter, while Duncan, after a short silence, finally could not help speaking: “…Alice.”

“Ah?”

“Not everyone has to fight the kitchenware when they cook…”

“I know. The kitchens in the city-states do not hit people. But this is a ship, is it not?”

“…And not every ship has barrels, mops, and pots and pans that hit people.”

Alice opened her eyes wide in surprise.

Two seconds later, the doll let out a cry: “That is so amazing?”

Duncan: “…”

Just then, Lucretia noticed the strange wooden box Alice was holding in her other arm. “And what is this? Also your spoils?”

“Yes,” Alice answered at once and nodded again and again. “I found it in a strange cabin. There was only this wooden box in such a big room, and several iron chains were wrapped around the box. I pulled off most of the chains, but the lock on the box was very strange. No matter how much strength I used, I could not open it. I do not even know what is inside, so I just took the whole box…”

As she spoke, she handed the big wooden box in her arms to Duncan. “Will you take a look?”

While Alice was still talking, a strange sense of intuition had already risen in Duncan’s heart. He took the heavy wooden box from her. Its surface was black and covered with many complex patterns. His gaze slid to the lock, yet he saw only an ordinary looking iron lock, the kind even the clumsiest thief could open with a bit of wire. But this very lock had stopped the very strong doll.

Duncan knew how strong Alice was. She could swing a coffin lid and row a coffin across the sea at the speed of an assault boat, and she could tear apart iron chains meant to bind the box just by force. Duncan could even picture this silly girl rushing into the cabin and ripping those chains off with brute strength, yet left helpless in front of the last shabby little lock on the box.

It seemed that this box was exactly what he had been looking for.

Lucretia came closer and quickly recognized what was going on with the iron lock Alice could not open by force. “Anomaly 132-Lock,” she said. “It needs a special key to open it. The key is a spoken passphrase known only to the one who locked it. After it is locked, it becomes indestructible, and it makes the container it locks indestructible as well, even if that is only a paper box. This anomaly is one of the few harmless anomalies. Its number is not high, but it has a special use. It can help seal dangerous items. In 1876, it was stolen from a transport ship during a pirate attack… I did not expect it to fall into the hands of these cultists.”

After she finished sharing the information about this iron lock, Lucretia thought for a moment and then said, not very sure: “The cultist who last performed the locking is already dead, and the key phrase has been lost. But I can try other ways to solve the puzzle of this lock. Even though it is ‘indestructible’, I have heard that it has a loophole…”

A soft click suddenly sounded, cutting off the rest of the witch’s words.

Lucretia stared in shock at the wooden box in Duncan’s hands.

The lock had opened on its own.

“It seems it does not want to let you try,” Duncan said with a smile to Lucretia. “Or perhaps it knows that if your attempt did not work, then it would be my turn to ‘try’ it myself.”

Lucretia froze for a moment. “…That is reasonable. My thinking was limited.”

Duncan shook his head with a smile, then set the big wooden box on the deck, took off the opened padlock, and carefully lifted the lid.

A black wooden carving of Goathead lay quietly inside the box.

Chapter 664: Goathead

Duncan looked at the Goathead in the wooden box. The Goathead in the box looked like a real wood carving, lifeless and unresponsive as it met his gaze.

Duncan was not surprised. From the moment Alice had muddled her way onto the deck with a wooden box that could not be opened and had clearly been carefully sealed, he had guessed that what he was looking for was inside.

After all, the silly beauty was missing a few points in the brain, so she had to make up for it in other areas, like her grip, her optimism, and her good luck.

“Goathead!” Alice craned her neck to look into the box. She finally realized what she had brought back so muddle-headedly, and her eyes instantly went wide with surprise: “This is the one the cultist was holding? It really looks exactly like the Goathead on the Vanished!”

Duncan did not speak. He just carefully studied the details of this “Dream-Skull”. Beside him, Lucretia crouched down and poked the Goathead in the box with her small Conductor’s Baton. Her beautiful brows drew together slightly: “No reaction… I also can’t see any traits of being alive, and it doesn’t seem to be giving off any special aura either?”

“Just like a real piece of wood.” Duncan nodded, reached into the box, took the carved Goathead out, and weighed it up and down in his hand: “…So it’s actually this light.”

“Have you never taken the Goathead on the Vanished off its base?” When Lucretia heard this, she looked at Duncan in some surprise. “It always seemed to just sit on the table…”

“They are connected. Goathead is part of the Vanished as a whole.” Duncan shook his head at once. “Its head can turn around, but it cannot be removed from the table.”

This was the first time Lucretia had heard this detail, and she seemed to find it quite incredible. Beside her, after hearing the captain’s words, Alice suddenly showed a thoughtful look. Then she clapped her hands: “So that’s how it is!”

Duncan turned his head at once: “Hm?”

“I was wondering why, last time when I tried to take the First Mate’s head off the table, it resisted so much and muttered a whole bunch of things at me. I don’t remember what it said though…”

Duncan stared: “Why did you try to take the First Mate’s head off the table?”

“Because I wanted to wipe the table,” Alice said, as if this were only natural. “And I wanted to take it to the washroom and give it a rinse… but I couldn’t get it off.”

Duncan: “…?”

He no longer wanted to imagine what that scene had looked like—thankfully this doll did not have that much strength in her hands. If it had been Vanna instead, Saslokar might have died a third time…

Lucretia suddenly noticed that Father’s expression flickered a few times.

“What is it?” she asked, unable to hold back her concern.

“…I don’t think I ever reminded the others on the ship that Goathead’s head is fixed to the table and cannot be taken off.”

“Miss Vanna is a steady person. She probably wouldn’t just walk into your captain’s cabin.”

Duncan looked puzzled: “Why was Vanna the first person you thought of?”

Lucretia froze for two seconds, then gave Duncan a rather odd look: “Then who did you think of?”

Duncan thought about it and decided it was better not to keep talking about this topic that was getting more and more ridiculous. He turned his attention back to the “Dream-Skull” in front of him.

“This should indeed be another shard of Saslokar. Otherwise those cultists would not have sealed it up so carefully. But shards differ from shard to shard. Not every ‘Goathead’ has a complete mind.”

As he spoke, he placed the pitch-black wooden Goathead back into the box and closed the lid again. Anomaly 132 at once jumped up from the nearby deck, hung itself on the box’s latch, and with a click, locked itself in place.

“I will send this thing back to the Vanished first and see what happens when I place it together with the Goathead on the ship.”

“Ah, are we going back already?” Alice reacted at once. She stood up with Duncan and looked curiously at the distant sea. “I thought we were going to follow this ship straight to that… what was it… the ‘home port’.”

The one who answered her was Lucretia: “We are still far from the border. Even at its highest speed, this ship would need about a week to reach the area near The Veil. There is no need for us to stay on this almost completely ruined ghost ship for that long.”

“Mm.” Duncan nodded and added: “We can use this time to move the survivors from the prison to the city-states. Then, if we get the chance, we can contact the Four Gods Church. They may also be interested in a cult nest hidden in the mist near the border. And then there is the ‘Goathead’ in this box… there is a lot to do.”

“You can go back first. I will handle the aftermath here,” Lucretia offered. “I have quite a bit of… experience with such things.”

He only nodded slightly and did not say more.

He knew that as a Witch who had wandered the Boundless Sea for a century, Lucretia’s experiences had long surpassed those of ordinary people. City-states struck by disaster, stranded expedition teams, cursed sea ships, and victims kidnapped and offered up in the sacrificial rites of cults—she had dealt with all these before.

She knew how to settle those survivors whose bodies and minds were already on the verge of collapse.

“Then Alice and I will return to the Vanished first.” Duncan nodded to Lucretia, then patted the rail beside him. “This ship will sail back to its home port on its own. You don’t need to worry about it. After you finish dealing with things here, leave that ‘artificial beacon’ on the ship. That way I can monitor its condition at any time and come back here when the time is right.”

Lucretia lowered her head: “I understand.”

The sharp crackle of leaping flames rose out of thin air on the deck. When she looked up again, a spinning door of fire had already appeared before her.

Alice, holding the big wooden box (and her string of “spoils of war”), was the first to step into the whirling flames. Then Duncan waved toward her

side, and his body, wreathed in spirit form flames, turned into a streak of fire in an instant and vanished through the gate.

In the place where Duncan had just been standing, a clump of lingering fire still burned calmly in midair. It slowly shrank and dimmed, and soon turned into a magic item no larger than a palm, which fell onto the deck.

That was the artificial beacon the Sea Witch had made.

Lucretia took a step forward and picked the beacon up from the deck.

It was a small puppet, carved from a piece of wood taken from the rail of the Vanished. Inside it was tucked a strand of Duncan's hair. It had been roughly carved into Duncan's likeness: wearing a captain's uniform from the Old Era, a gloomy captain's hat, and a stern beard.

The puppet's overall shape looked somewhat exaggerated, but in just the right way.

Lucretia had spent a whole night making this puppet. For a Witch who had created an entire army of Servants, this task was not complicated. This incredible magic construct could hold a trace of Father's power. Even though its "capacity" was very small, it was enough to replace a human body and let Father open a door of flames near the beacon's location without adding another avatar form.

Father did not wish to occupy more bodies to create more avatar forms. To Lucretia, this was a very good thing. She was happy to use her skills to help Father solve the "practical inconveniences" that came with it.

On the deck, the remaining flames of the fire gate slowly faded.

Holding the small puppet in Duncan's likeness, Lucretia lifted it and examined it back and forth in the sunlight. Then, like a thief, she suddenly glanced quickly to either side.

There was of course no one else here.

So the Witch young lady withdrew her gaze from the empty surroundings, walked to a corner, hesitated for a moment, and reached out to poke the puppet’s head with her finger.

The puppet had no reaction.

She reached out again, poked the puppet’s beard, then poked its exaggerated captain’s hat. She began to laugh, and her expression slowly grew cheerful.

Suddenly the puppet lifted its head and spoke in a helpless voice: “Having fun?”

Lucretia: “…”

A moment later, Rabby the rabbit, who had just crawled out of the cabin and was about to find her mistress to report something, heard a scream that echoed across the whole deck, a scream the like of which she had never heard in her life.

…

The clanging of metal broke the calm on the deck of the Vanished.

Duncan gave a somewhat helpless look at Alice, who was walking back and forth on the deck with her “spoils of war”: “Give me the box. You can take your ‘spoils’ to the kitchen first.”

“Oh!”

The doll answered happily and casually handed Duncan the wooden box holding the “Dream-Skull”. Then she walked toward the kitchen, accompanied by a trail of clanging sounds.

The noise of cleavers, spatulas, and iron spoons knocking together finally grew distant.

Duncan held the wooden box containing the “Dream-Skull” and watched Alice’s cheerful back as she left. At the same time he sensed the information coming from the artificial beacon in some far, unknown sea area. A subtle yet helpless expression slowly appeared on his face. He shook his head, smiling and sighing at the same time.

“…Forget it. As long as she is happy.”

He turned and walked toward the aft deck. As soon as he pushed open the door of the captain’s cabin, he immediately met Goathead’s gaze.

It was as if Goathead had already turned its gaze toward the door before he opened it. Now those obsidian-carved eyes were deep and still. The “First Mate”, who normally chattered endlessly and never acted serious, for the first time did not recite its dizzying, patter-like opening speech. Its eyes were fixed tightly on the wooden box Duncan held in his hands, as if it had already guessed what was inside.

“Looks like you sensed it,” Duncan said as he walked to the chart table and set the big wooden box on it. “I brought you a gift.”

Chapter 665: Boundary Crossing Again

Under Duncan's gaze, Anomaly 132—the "lock"—sensibly opened itself, slipped off the hasp, and jumped to the other side of the table where it would not be in the way.

Duncan opened the dark wooden box, took out the carved Goathead inside, and set it on the chart table.

The "First Mate" at the edge of the table turned its head and stared at the carved Goathead that looked exactly like itself. Two pairs of eyes, carved like obsidian, met each other. After a long time, it let out a drawn-out sigh: "Wow—"

Duncan raised an eyebrow: "That is all you have to say?"

"It is too shocking. That was the only thing that came to mind." Goathead's head twisted back and forth on its base, as if trying hard to study its "other head" from different angles. It stretched its neck as far as it could and stared for quite a while, muttering as it did so: "I already had a faint feeling when you came back on board. And once you went to that ship, you were sure to bring this 'Dream-Skull' back, so that part did not surprise me. It is just that seeing it with my own eyes is still unbelievable. There really is one that looks exactly like me…"

It suddenly stopped there, sounding a bit puzzled: "Why is it not moving at all?"

“You are asking me?” Duncan gave him a strange look. “This is your own head.”

“But I am not familiar with it,” Goathead said in a very righteous tone. “Before this trip to Lightwind Harbor I did not even know I had a backbone…”

Duncan was speechless: “…”

The awkward and strange mood lasted for a few seconds. Goathead finally moved again and stretched its neck toward the “Dream-Skull”: “Could you bring it a bit closer?”

“Like this?” Duncan held the lifeless “Dream-Skull” next to Goathead and watched curiously. “Do you feel anything?”

“…Maybe a little closer?”

Duncan moved it a bit closer, and then a bit more. At last he simply pressed the “Dream-Skull” right against Goathead’s forehead, making the two carved Goatheads touch head to head: “All right, that is close enough. Do you feel anything or not?”

“Take it away, take it away… that is close enough,” Goathead cried, twisting his neck. Only when Duncan put the “Dream-Skull” back on the table did he let out a very human-like breath and mutter: “Still nothing. Aside from being able to sense its ‘existence’ very clearly, I cannot establish any ‘communication’ with this head. I cannot sense any thoughts or memories in it, and it is not responding to me either…”

He paused and thought it over, then shook his head: “It feels like just an empty shell. Aside from ‘existing’ and being ‘of the same source’, it seems to have nothing to do with me.”

Listening to Goathead’s description, Duncan frowned deeply.

“This situation is not quite what I expected,” he said, still frowning. “This is, after all, another shard of Saslokar. Even if it is a much more damaged part, it should still have some special traits. And the sacrificial ritual those cultists held before proved that this ‘Dream-Skull’ did have some ‘activity’… so why is there no reaction at all after contact with you?”

“I do not know, but at least I am sure this head is absolutely real—I really can feel its ‘existence’. The feeling is very subtle, and I do not know how to explain it to you…” Goathead spoke, then began to guess: “Maybe we are just using the wrong way to make contact? Or… maybe those cultists messed up the sacrificial ritual and broke this head? After all, those bastards kept using elf blood to stimulate the ‘Dream-Skull’…”

Duncan’s expression grew serious and thoughtful. He glanced at Goathead again: “Those cultists are indeed bastards—but do you not feel strange talking about your other head being ‘broken’?”

“Of course it is strange, but I cannot think of a better word,” Goathead said helplessly. “Look at the state I am in now. I am completely dead and shattered anyway…”

Duncan: “…”

He had noticed that after the Lightwind Harbor incident, his First Mate had changed in some ways. The most obvious point was how big-hearted he had become, almost to a degree that seemed unhealthy…

Duncan shook his head, pushing aside the strange thought that had just flashed through his mind. Then he patted the lifeless “Dream-Skull” with his hand.

“In any case, the current state of this ‘Dream-Skull’ is definitely not right. Maybe those cultists really did something to it that changed it. Or maybe we just have not found the right way to awaken it. Or… perhaps it is

‘missing’ something. In any event, I will leave it here for now and let you watch for any changes. What do you think?”

“I will follow whatever you arrange,” Goathead said at once. “And I am very curious about this head myself. Leaving it here will let me study it whenever I have time.”

Duncan nodded slightly: “Good.”

Then he lifted his gaze and looked out the window.

The setting sun had already sunk a third of the way below the horizon. Before he knew it, dusk was near. The remaining golden-red radiance of Vision 001 spread magnificently over the Boundless Sea. In another direction, the golden sunlight from the glowing geometric body near Lightwind Harbor grew even more dazzling as dusk approached. Between those crisscrossing beams of light, the silhouette of the distant city-state looked a little hazy.

How long could such a peaceful sunset scene last?

For some reason, such a thought suddenly rose in Duncan’s heart. But then he sighed softly and set those stray thoughts aside.

“I am going back to my room to rest for a while. Once Lucretia finishes dealing with things on her side, I will go into the city with her again. Take good care of the Vanished during this time.”

“Yes, Captain.”

Duncan nodded, stood up, and walked toward the bedroom door at the back of the captain’s cabin. Suddenly he stopped again and looked curiously at Goathead on the table: “You said you wanted to ‘study’ this Dream-Skull. How are you going to study it? You do not even have hands.”

“That is a good question,” Goathead mused. After a moment he lifted his head with full confidence: “I will start by trying to talk to it. Maybe those cultists made this head shut itself off. If I counsel it a bit, I might help it untie the knot in its heart…”

Duncan at once gave up any hope for Goathead’s “research”.

But he did not say anything. He only gave Goathead a look that said “do your best”, waved his hand, and turned to walk into the bedroom.

With a bang, the dark wooden door closed.

In the empty captain’s cabin, only the two carved Goatheads on the table were left in their own quiet.

This silence lasted for an unknown time before Goathead finally turned his head and looked at the motionless “Dream-Skull”.

“…Have you heard of the eighteen cuisines of the Boundless Sea?”

…

After dozing off for only a few minutes, Duncan suddenly woke with a start because of a rumbling noise that seemed to come from nowhere.

He rose quickly from the bed, but the cabin and the space outside were already quiet again.

In the dim bedroom, only a consecrated lantern on the desk gave off a light that seemed a bit too weak. Outside the nearby window it was pitch-black, as if the veil of night had already been hanging there for a long time. It was silent beyond the door, and no sound came from the direction of the corridor or the deck.

Duncan sat on the edge of the bed in the dark. A vague feeling of pressure rose in him from some unknown place. He remembered what had happened

before he came back to his room to rest, and then he noticed something wrong in his surroundings.

It was too quiet—not even the sound of waves hitting the hull could be heard. The “veil of night” outside the window also seemed too dark. He could see neither the fading “sunlight” from the glowing geometric body near Lightwind Harbor nor the cold glow spread over the sea by the World’s Wound.

Duncan frowned and suddenly felt something. He left the bed quickly and went to the window beside his desk.

In the endless dim void, a band of turbid, dark radiance slid silently past in the far distance outside the window. In the space briefly lit by that light, some huge, twisted shadows slowly rose at the edge of his sight, rolling without a sound.

Subspace!

Duncan’s heart gave a sudden jolt, and he realized at once what had happened.

After so long, he had “wandered” into Subspace again!?

He still remembered what it had been like the first time he entered Subspace. He also remembered that it had happened after a “nap” as well, and that he had at first thought it was a strange “dream”. That was also the only time he had ever entered this “time and space” that the world saw as forbidden. After that, so much time had gone by that he had almost forgotten it.

Now the same thing had happened again.

Duncan frowned and silently raised his guard. First he summoned a clump of flame and hid it in his hand, then he walked carefully toward the door.

He no longer treated this as some kind of “sleepwalking”.

Because he knew that he did not dream. Even though he did not know the reason behind it, “dreams” did not seem to belong to him.

He came to the bedroom door and listened at it for a moment. Then he slowly pushed it open.

Outside was the dim, deathly still captain’s cabin. The ruined other “Vanished” appeared in his sight just as it had last time, showing signs of being abandoned for a century everywhere. Empty shelves leaned crookedly in the corners. A dirty Oval Scrying Mirror hung on the cracked and mottled wall. Piles of black, suspicious shadowy junk lay on the floor. The only intact chart table stood alone in the center of the room, and the mysterious enchanted sea chart on it gave off a faint glow.

A pitch-black carved wooden Goathead sat quietly on the table. It slowly lifted its head and fixed its gaze on Duncan.

Chapter 666: gaze

Even though a long time had passed since his last visit to Subspace, Duncan still clearly remembered that on this ruined version of the Vanished, on the Subspace side, there had been no Goathead in the captain’s cabin.

On the chart table here, there had only been a single enchanted sea chart, showing eerie and suspicious routes.

Now, however, a pitch-black Goathead sat quietly on the chart table. In the dim light, it silently fixed its gaze on him. At the same time, Duncan was sure that the instant he had opened the bedroom door, this black Goathead had turned its eyes toward him.

It was a living thing. It was reacting to outside stimuli.

Duncan quickly forced his expression under control. While he carefully watched the Goathead that was staring straight at him, he walked out of the bedroom and slowly approached the chart table. As he moved, the Goathead on the table reacted as well. It slowly turned its gaze, and its eyes stayed on Duncan the whole time.

Duncan suddenly frowned.

This Goathead looked exactly the same as the Goathead in the Mortal Realm, but something was off about its position. In the Mortal Realm, the “Goathead” sat at the left edge of the table. The one before his eyes, though, was placed closer to the middle.

Duncan quickly searched his memory and soon remembered. Before he had gone back to the bedroom to rest, he had placed the “Dream-Skull” in that very spot.

The Dream-Skull? This was the Dream-Skull he had brought back from the cultists’ ship. Why had it appeared here in Subspace?!

Countless messy guesses and thoughts surged up at once in his mind. Duncan cautiously walked to the side of the chart table. He braced both hands on the edge of the table and, with a face like still water, stared at the Goathead on the table. The Goathead slowly raised its gaze, its hollow eyes meeting Duncan’s.

That silent, empty gaze was a little horrifying.

After a few seconds of this quiet standoff, Duncan decided to break the silence. He kept his face tight, his expression serious, and greeted it: “Hello, I am Duncan.”

The strange Goathead on the table spoke: “Hello. You are not Duncan.”

For a moment, Duncan almost failed to hold his expression together.

But the thick nerves he had trained up by dealing with all the oddballs on the ship finally did their work. At the critical moment, his face stayed stiff. Only the storm in his heart was not so easy to calm—this eerie Goathead had actually spoken?!

And more shocking than the fact that it had spoken was what it said.

Controlling the changes on his face, Duncan forced himself to speak in a calm tone as he asked: “If I am not Duncan, then who am I?”

“You are the captain,” the Goathead, which seemed to be the Dream-Skull, said calmly.

When it spoke, its voice was almost exactly the same as the “First Mate” Duncan knew so well, but there was a strange gloom and bluntness in it. It felt very unsettling.

As Duncan tried to get used to this odd feeling, he looked at the eerie Goathead with a strange expression. What it said sounded very strange to him, so he could not help asking again: “Isn’t the captain of this ship Duncan?”

“You are the captain,” the Goathead said, meeting Duncan’s gaze. “You are not Duncan.”

It seemed that these were the only words it could say. No matter how he questioned it, no matter how he changed the way he asked, its response never went beyond those two lines. The person speaking to it right now was the captain of this ship, but that person was not “Duncan.”

After a few rounds of questions, Duncan stopped probing in this direction. A thoughtful look came over his face.

He was the captain of this ship, but he was not Duncan—of course he knew he was not Duncan.

He was Zhou Ming, a wandering soul. The identity of the great explorer named Duncan Abnomar was only something he had “occupied” for now. The real Captain Duncan had died a century ago. That, he knew.

But all this time, only he knew this—well, to be exact, the Goathead First Mate in the Mortal Realm might also know, but it would never say it out loud.

This was a fact that could not be announced on the Vanished.

Yet the Goathead that seemed to be the Dream-Skull in front of him had spoken this truth directly.

Duncan raised his head and looked at the ruined cabin around him, then through the empty windows toward the broken masts, the deck, and the distant rail outside.

This shattered Vanished sailing through Subspace did not change at all just because someone in the captain's cabin had torn open the secret that "the captain is not Duncan."

Was it because this was Subspace? Because this ship was only a projection? Or was it because the Dream-Skull that had pointed it out was not a part of the Vanished, so its knowledge could not affect the ship's stability?

Duncan slowly drew back his gaze and looked down again at the Goathead on the table.

Then what exactly was this Goathead? Was it the true body of the Dream-Skull, or only the Dream-Skull's projection in Subspace? Or… had the Dream-Skull been split into two parts from the very beginning, one part found by the cultists, and the other always left here in Subspace?

After frowning in thought for a while, Duncan tried asking: "Who are you?"

The Goathead on the table fell silent. A long time passed, and just when Duncan thought it was not going to answer him, it suddenly opened its mouth: "I do not know."

Duncan suddenly felt a little curious: "Then what do you know?"

This time the Goathead stayed silent even longer. When it finally spoke, its answer was still the same: "I do not know."

"…You do not know anything, yet you know I am the 'captain' here, and you also know I am not Duncan," Duncan said, his expression a bit odd. "Then do you know this ship? Do you know where you are?"

The Goathead did not respond at all. It stayed silent and still, as if it had become a real wooden carving.

Duncan slowly understood. The mind of this “Dream-Skull” was not complete.

Unlike the “First Mate” in the Mortal Realm, this Dream-Skull seemed to have only a few scattered memories and a broken, fragmented way of thinking. Even though it showed some ability to talk here in Subspace, that ability only let it answer a few questions. As soon as a question went “out of range,” it fell into stillness.

Yet within this damaged and fragmented mind, the Dream-Skull still knew that the “captain” of this ship right now was not “Duncan.”

Duncan fell into thought. A vague guess was already forming in his heart.

This might still be tied to that “deal” the real Captain Duncan had made with Saslokar deep in Subspace a century ago.

In that deal, the Vanished, which had almost been fully swallowed and assimilated by Subspace, had been reshaped into a real ship again by the King of Dreams. In return, the King of Dreams, broken and trapped deep in Subspace, had gained a chance to escape. Even though what escaped was only a spine and a shard of skull, and even though almost all memory had been lost, Saslokar had indeed returned to the Mortal Realm.

The Dream-Skull before him should be one of the fragments that had failed to escape from Subspace back then. It had gone through that deal as well, so it knew what had happened to the real Captain Duncan, but it remembered it only in broken pieces.

Duncan had a strong feeling that this Dream-Skull still knew more—more about Saslokar, about Subspace, and about the Vanished of that time.

But its damaged and chaotic thinking could not sort out those scattered memories.

Just as Duncan’s thoughts followed this path and he began to consider how he might use mental guidance on this Dream-Skull to get more answers, a light tremor and a strange noise from some unknown direction suddenly broke his train of thought.

The Vanished was shaking. Something outside the hull seemed to be drawing near.

Duncan lifted his head from the table at once and, by instinct, looked toward the nearby window.

Vast, rolling shadows, and a pale, cracked “land,” had appeared at some unknown time in the endless darkness outside the window. That huge pale structure moved slowly past the ship. On its surface, besides shocking cracks and wounds, there were lines and patterns that looked almost like skin.

Duncan’s heart suddenly jolted, as if he had thought of something. He strode quickly to the window.

At that moment, new shapes appeared on that slowly moving “pale land” outside the window—first a widened fissure, then dark yellow, murky crystals, and then a huge mass of eye tissue that almost filled the entire view outside.

A gigantic eye was slowly moving past the captain’s window.

Duncan stood at the window, watching that cloudy single eye slide across his field of view. As his sight moved with it, he saw the structures around it—a pale, inhuman face.

Then his gaze went even farther. He saw the immense body that rose and fell in the darkness, and the broken land that seemed to be “embedded” all

around that body.

It was the pale, one-eyed giant that bore a shattered land on its back in Subspace.

Duncan suddenly remembered. The first time he had entered Subspace, he had seen this shocking being from afar.

But that time he had only skimmed past at a distance and had not even had time to see any real detail of the giant or the land on its back. This time, the Vanished was gliding past right against the giant’s face.

The impact and shock of this sight were far stronger than before. Even Duncan felt a sense of suffocation for a moment.

He kept his gaze on the slowly moving giant outside the window, on that cloudy, dead eye.

That dead, cloudy eye also quietly gazed back at him. As the Vanished moved, the eyeball slowly turned. In the chaos of Subspace, it calmly fixed its gaze on Duncan.

Duncan: “…?!”

He blinked and checked again. The giant’s cloudy eye really was turning slowly as the Vanished passed. That eye had seen the Vanished. It was staring at this ship.

Chapter 667: Reflection in the Eye

In the boundless, chaotic darkness, at the far end of a shattered continent, the one-eyed giant was gazing at the ghost ship passing close by. This “Elder God,” which had been dead for an unknown number of centuries, silently turned its cloudy eye. It was as if that eye had briefly awakened from the long river of time and was following the uninvited guest that had broken into this place.

Duncan stared hard at that eye. His whole body grew tighter bit by bit. Even if he would not suffer the so-called mental corruption, he still felt a suffocating pressure in the face of such a sight. But he did not make any rash move. He did not try to respond to that eye in any way. He simply let the Vanished slowly sail past the giant’s face and watched the eye, turning to its limit, slowly recede toward the stern.

The pale, one-eyed giant did nothing else. It still bore that broken mass of land on its back, floating in the endless, chaotic dark.

From behind Duncan, the Goathead that seemed to be the Dream-Skull suddenly spoke: “giants was the first to die.”

Duncan jerked around and looked at the “Dream-Skull” sitting honestly on the table.

“What did you say?” he could not help asking again.

“giants was the first to die,” the Dream-Skull repeated. Its tone and wording did not change at all. After that, no matter how Duncan questioned it, this was the only answer it gave.

Realizing that this broken fragment of an Elder God could only give this one response right now, Duncan did not keep pressing it. Instead, he turned back and looked at the one-eyed giant slowly fading outside the hull. After a long moment, he murmured to himself: “When the stars shattered and fell apart, the pale giant king Salmir died in the first Long Night…”

In the endless darkness outside the porthole, a faint layer of noise seemed to appear quietly when he spoke the name “Salmir,” then faded away like the wind.

Duncan glanced once more toward where the one-eyed giant lay, then suddenly frowned. After a brief hesitation, he stepped toward the captain’s door.

Before he left, he looked back once at the Dream-Skull on the chart table.

It was still staring at him. The obsidian-carved eyes were empty and dead.

Duncan ignored that unsettling gaze and turned to leave the captain’s cabin.

He climbed the slanted steps from the aft deck to the helm platform above the captain’s room. He walked across the lifeless, mottled, rotten planks. At the end of the platform, the heavy helm waited for him, swaying slightly left and right against the dark background of Subspace.

It felt like a silent invitation.

Duncan walked up to the dark-colored helm and took a deep breath.

He was about to do something bold. Taking the helm of this broken Vanished in Subspace was only the first step.

Once he calmed himself, he reached out, gripped the helm, and released the Power of Flame.

In an instant, fire spread out. The invisible, unreal fire of his spirit form swept over the whole ship in the blink of an eye. Then it slowly became

transparent and faded away into nothing. Duncan felt his perception suddenly expand, and then that familiar feeling of “emptiness” came back with the feedback from the spreading flames.

He once again felt the emptiness of the Vanished and sensed its phantom nature. The flames seemed to spread directly through Subspace itself, touching nothing but cold and void.

But this time Duncan was ready. He did not let the shock of this “emptiness” cut off his link with the fire. He ignored the unease of feeling as if he were floating helplessly in Subspace without any protection. Instead, he focused more of his attention on the helm before him. He tried to give this helm real substance and control this phantom ghost ship through it.

Creaking noises rose from beneath the helm. The whole phantom ship began to tremble slightly. The spirit form sails filled out. In some unseen distance, it felt as if cheering came from far away, echoing from every direction.

The captain had returned.

Duncan slowly turned the helm. He felt the ghost ship floating in the darkness tilt a little and adjust its heading according to his control.

A strange feeling rose in his heart. He had truly taken control of this ghost ship sailing in Subspace. What was more, he even felt that sailing through Subspace was easier and smoother than sailing in the Mortal Realm.

The Vanished traced an arc through the dark. The bow turned one hundred and eighty degrees and faced once more the fragment of a heavenly body that looked as if it had been torn from a planet. The pale, one-eyed giant that had already drifted far away appeared again in Duncan’s view and slowly drew closer.

Duncan steered the ship back toward this Elder God.

When the Vanished came within a certain distance, the giant's cloudy single eye on that pale face turned again. In the dark, it stared silently at Duncan.

Duncan acted as if he did not care about this gaze at all. During their close brush earlier, he had already noticed that this eye's stare had no effect on him. Compared to the nervousness such a gaze might cause, he now cared far more about gathering information.

The Vanished slowly closed in on the giant's face. In Duncan's view, the cloudy eye grew larger and larger until it almost filled the entire height of the hull's side.

Duncan stopped the ship here, let go of the helm, and walked over to the rail to study the eye up close.

The giant's eyeball shifted slightly, its empty pupil turning toward him. The dead, cloudy eye was veiled by a layer of pale mist inside the globe. Duncan saw his own figure reflected on that misty surface, blurry and unreal.

"…What are you looking at?" Duncan suddenly asked in a low voice, driven by some feeling he could not name.

But he got no answer. The giant really was dead. The turning of that eye seemed to be only some "inertia" left after the ancient God's death, or a faint "aftershock" in that massive corpse, maintaining a false image of life.

Duncan suddenly remembered a saying: after the Universal Extinction, in the cooling embers, the corpses of the Elder Gods ruled over the ashes of the world.

These dead Gods, even if they died again, and even if another long age passed after that, their remains still kept a certain level of "operation." Their death was a strange, indescribable state. Even if they were broken into

countless fragments like Goathead, twisted into impossible shapes, this “operation” would go on. It was as if this long process could continue forever.

Duncan still did not really understand what these so-called “Gods,” or the ancient Elder Kings, truly were, or what state they were in now. But from this pale giant king before him, he felt that he was slowly touching some “face of the Truth.”

Just then, Duncan suddenly frowned.

He seemed to see something.

Inside the giant’s cloudy eye, behind that misty veil, there seemed to be something else.

Duncan leaned in a little closer and studied the murky reflection even more carefully. He tried hard to pick out recognizable shapes from the shadows marked by the traces of time. Gradually, he finally picked out some things.

First he saw a huge being, with the fierce look of some sea beast yet a graceful and holy air. This being stood at the front. Beside it, there was a human-shaped figure wrapped in flames, standing to one side. Behind these two shapes, he could see some vague, glowing things. They seemed like a row of ordered lights, set into the surface of a giant cube.

Besides these, there were giants in black robes, like corpses; twisted, unspeakable masses; shadowy clouds floating above all these beings; tall, thin, crooked limbs; thick clusters of thorns; and pale golden arcs of light…

Many hazy, ghostly outlines like these were reflected in the giant’s eye. Each had a strange form. They stood in silence and solemn stillness in the dark.

Duncan stared, stunned, at those figures that seemed to pour out endless power even as mere reflections. Only after nearly half a minute did he

suddenly realize what he was seeing.

These were “Gods,” the images of the ancient Elder Kings.

The single eye of the giant was reflecting a scene from long, long ago. In an age even older than ancient times, in some veil of night between the Great Annihilation and the Deep Sea era, these towering beings had once gathered here. They had stood in silence around the giant, surrounding it.

Their forms had been branded deep into this cloudy eye.

This had been a funeral.

It was the moment when the Gods saw off the pale giant king after his failed act of creation and death.

Duncan’s thoughts spun fast. At the same time, countless new ideas rose in his mind. Using the tales known in the world and the information he had recently gathered, he tried to match each reflected form in the giant’s eye with something he knew. But aside from the known Four Gods and a few other Elder Gods, most of the figures had no match in any legend or record.

More than half of those forms were completely unknown to him. They were not in the orthodox scriptures. Even in the wild myths and twisted stories of the cultists, he could find nothing about them.

Duncan stood there in silence.

If each “God” stood for a powerful civilization that had survived the end of the world, then it seemed that more than half of the Elder Gods had already fallen quietly before the third Long Night. Not even The Blasphemous Tome had kept their names.

Ancient Elder Kings who had died in the act of creation, like the pale giant king and the King of Dreams, were actually the lucky ones among these fallen beings.

Duncan let out a soft sigh and stepped back, ready to turn and leave.

But in that sigh, he noticed another detail.

His own figure was now reflected in the giant’s eye as well.

The reflection stood among the ancient Elder Kings whose forms had been frozen in the long river of time.

There was an empty place there, not too big and not too small.

It was as if, a hundred centuries ago, when those beings had gathered here to see off the pale giant king, they had already left that spot open.

Chapter 668: Held in Starlight

Among the many figures reflected in the chaotic single eye of the Pale giant King, one place was left empty—was it a coincidence, or the deliberate work of the ancient Elder Kings?

Duncan only knew that when he walked to the rail and carefully examined that giant eye, he happened to be standing in front of that empty spot. His figure reflected there, and only after he picked out the other unspeakable shapes from the murky sediment and mist on the eye's surface did he notice this.

It might really have been just a coincidence—he wanted very much to tell himself that. But in Subspace, before the corpse of an Elder God, he did not believe in coincidences like this.

Duncan's brow tightened. He then carefully, bit by bit, slowly stepped back, as if afraid of waking something that slept here.

The dead Pale giant King, and the figures of the Elder Kings reflected in that eye—Duncan always felt that these beings were silently laying a gaze upon him, watching his every move, like a distant gaze cast from the long river of time.

Moving with cautious, slow steps, he left the space directly before the eye.

Yet in the next second, he saw his own figure appear again, once more quietly reflected in that eye, standing among the Elder Kings.

Duncan’s eyes widened a little at once. He felt as if his heart suddenly skipped half a beat, and right after that, an even more unexpected sight appeared:

The image of himself left in the giant’s eye began to change.

That tall, imposing blur in a captain’s uniform and gloomy tricorn hat started to shake and shift, as if some illusion was fading. The figure quickly turned into another form—a “human” in a white shirt and black trousers, not very strong, with a face so blurred it could not be made out.

That was Zhou Ming.

Zhou Ming stood motionless on the deck, like a statue, staring fixedly at the murky giant eye only a step away from the rail, staring at the “self” reflected in that eye.

After an unknown time, he finally took a step forward and came once more to the front of the eye. Separated only by the layer of muddy mist clotted on the eyeball’s surface, he cast his gaze at his own hazy reflection and slowly reached out his hand.

He knew he was taking a risk. In this strange and dangerous Subspace, he was making a terrifying attempt—yet in the end, his fingertips still touched the surface of the eyeball.

A feeling of “nothingness” came from his fingertips. In just that instant, Zhou Ming understood what Lucretia had meant when she described the “void” she felt when she touched that cylindrical black shadow at the border.

He was sure he had touched something, but he did not feel any warmth. He did not feel any hardness. A broken and twisted “sensation” passed in from his fingers and left him stunned for a brief moment.

In the next instant, Zhou Ming saw the reflection of himself in the eye suddenly change. The “human” in the white shirt collapsed like an unstable phantom. Every bit of color that made up the image faded and broke apart in the blink of an eye, and as the colors vanished, countless pinpoints of light surged out from within!

A field of brilliant starlight replaced that quickly dissolving figure and spread outward into the darkness. For the first second, the stars still held a vague, twisted human outline, yet countless rays seemed to overflow from the edges of that shape. The light of a whole star river almost covered the entire eyeball in the blink of an eye, then kept overflowing, rising up—the starlight finally spilled out of the eyeball, spreading from its surface!

The light flowed like a stream and brushed against Zhou Ming’s fingers. At the instant of “contact,” Zhou Ming heard a thunderous roar inside his head.

It was countless booms piled on top of one another, the “tremor” created when a sea of information was pressed into a single moment. It was a vast set of data enough to explain the rules that governed the whole world, an entrance, a gate, and the advice and thoughts of billions of people. In that brief instant that might have been no longer than a single Planck time, yet felt eternal, Zhou Ming felt as if he were being torn apart. His mind rose and sank in the roar, struggling to catch the voices layered inside it. He felt he was just about to understand what those voices meant, and many broken fragments swarmed into his head, crashing through his reason—

“…We are humans… At this moment we stand at the end of all things.”

In that roar, in those countless fragments, one voice spoke like this.

Zhou Ming’s eyes flew wide.

“…We have almost understood every secret…

“…The laws that rule the stars… time and space, the rise and fall of information…

“Until we found that the end of time is destruction… an event beyond our models of thought… happening outside our universe…

“Moving forward along time’s arrow has become meaningless… Within our finite models… the chance of ending that event is zero… We have decided to send #*#%?@ backward to…

“We… named it… ‘Inverse Singularity’… In our calculations… after that event, the only fragment that can remain whole on any timeline lasts 0.002 seconds…

“You are Zhou Ming. You… from the old-calendar timestamp 2022-07-10-07-10-00-000… ending at 2022-07-10-07-10-00-002…

“It is now 41765-12c-32-15b. All things have ended before our eyes.

“Good luck to you.

“Good luck to them.

“Good luck to us…”

Boom—

Zhou Ming felt as if he suddenly stopped after an endless fall, torn free from some frozen instant. The countless overlapping roars turned into a distant, blurred impression in his mind. The part of him that still belonged to “human” reason came back in a split second, and in that brief, fragile moment of clarity, he stumbled backward.

But at some point, all that brilliant starlight had already faded.

The starlight that had overflowed from the giant’s eye was gone. The reflections on the surface of the eyeball had vanished as well—not only the

reflections of “Duncan,” “Zhou Ming,” and the Starlight giant, but also the figures that had once stood in the darkness, those shapes that symbolized the ancient Elder Kings.

The “shadows” that had gathered in this eye for a hundred centuries seemed to have been “washed” away by whatever had erupted in that instant of thunder, leaving only a hazy layer of murk that stood for death, covering the eyeball with no more information left to see.

Clearly, this eyeball was only some kind of “carrier of information,” and now, after one powerful outburst and flush of that information, everything on its surface had been wiped clean.

The surroundings grew quiet. There was no more noise, no more roaring. Subspace seemed to return to its eternal stillness. On the ruined deck of the Vanished, all things fell silent.

Yet the broken “fragments” that had rushed out in that instant of thunder still spun in Zhou Ming’s mind, like a never-ending storm that howled again and again through his reason and thoughts. Only after a long time did this “storm” slowly calm, turning into a deep impression and memory, lodged in his mind forever.

Zhou Ming stepped back a few paces and lifted a hand to press his forehead. He panted, and the wild beating of his heart slowly settled.

His ability to think returned to him.

Zhou Ming stood for a long time in the murky gloom of Subspace, letting its meaningless time flow past. He thought in that eternal silence, thought without stopping, until after an unknown span, his figure finally moved again.

He raised his head and looked into the distance.

The endless Subspace swallowed his gaze.

In that boundless darkness, countless other secrets must still be hidden—but he was already tired.

That single “roar” had almost drained all his strength. He had no energy left to steer this ghost ship deeper into that endless dark.

“…Time to go back.”

Zhou Ming muttered softly. At the same time, he walked to the captain’s door. He still remembered how to return from Subspace to the Mortal Realm. He only had to push open the Lost Ones’ Door here, step into another dark space, then open a door again inside that darkness, and he would return to the Mortal Realm dimension.

When he laid his hand on the handle of the Lost Ones’ Door, he paused. Then he turned his head and gave the boundless chaos behind him one last look.

He knew that sooner or later, he would come back.

Without hesitating again, he quickly and smoothly completed the “two-door” process of return.

When the familiar sound of waves entered his ears once more, and the salty, cool night wind brushed across his face, Duncan felt his heart finally grow calm again—he had returned to the familiar Mortal Realm.

He looked up. The cold glow of the World’s Wound poured down from high above onto the sea. Faint golden sunlight spread from the distant waters and twined with that pale light in the sky, sketching out the strange yet charming night view that belonged only to the region near Lightwind Harbor.

Soft creaks mixed with the nearby waves, with now and then the friction of ropes on the mast as they adjusted themselves.

Everything he had experienced in Subspace now felt like a bizarre dream.

Duncan shook his head. He knew, of course, that it was no dream. It was vital information, even a “truth” that pointed toward his own nature.

But for now he could only set these messy thoughts aside—for too much key information was still missing, and wild guesses would not lead to any real conclusion.

From the other side of the door came a sound from the captain’s cabin, the voice of his familiar First Mate.

“…I’ve finished talking about the customs of the Northern Seas. Now I’ll tell you about the Central Seas. I’m a very experienced seafarer, you know, the city-states of the Central Seas…”

A faint smile rose on Duncan’s face before he knew it. He felt himself relax a little again. Then he took a deep breath and opened the captain’s door.

At the edge of the chart table, Goathead, who had been chattering away at the other head, stopped at once and turned toward the captain standing in the doorway.

“Duncan Abnomar.” Duncan spoke casually before the creature could ask anything.

Goathead froze for a second, then its tone turned cheerful: “Ah! The captain is back!”

—

Chapter 669: The Captain and the Doll

Back in the familiar Mortal Realm, back aboard the familiar Vanished, with Goathead's familiar rambling in his ears—Duncan felt his heart grow steadier bit by bit. The exhaustion and tangled thoughts brought by that "roar" in Subspace also quieted a great deal.

He let out a soft breath and walked toward the chart table. Goathead seemed not to have noticed the trace of tiredness on the captain's face. It had clearly enjoyed talking to its heart's content for quite a while, and now it sounded rather excited as it began to boast: "Captain! Your loyal—well, everything after that can be left out—has made great progress! I had a very good talk with this head. We just talked our way from food on the Boundless Sea to poetry and song, and from poetry and song…"

Duncan glanced down at this noisy First Mate: "Did it answer you?"

Goathead paused, suddenly less sure of itself: "Well… not yet…"

But right after, it became full of confidence again: "But I think I'm almost there. With such open-hearted conversation, even a stone would start to talk. I think this head will soon be moved by my sincere words. Maybe in a little while it will greet you, Captain, and…"

"Save it," Duncan cut off Goathead at last, helpless. "That head will not answer you—most of it is still in Subspace."

Goathead let out a sharp little “crack,” like words had suddenly slammed on the brakes in its throat. It stared blankly for two seconds before finally reacting: “Did you say Subspace?”

“Didn’t you notice?” Duncan lifted a hand and pointed at the captain’s door. “I was resting in the bedroom, yet I came back out through the cabin door. While you were having your ‘open-hearted’ talk with your other head, I had already gone into Subspace and come back once.”

Goathead’s skull wobbled and began to tremble.

“Don’t shake like that. As you can see, nothing bad happened,” Duncan said offhandedly as he sat down beside the chart table. His gaze fell on the other, pitch-black “Goathead” on the tabletop. “The Dream-Skull didn’t answer you because its main body is in Subspace. I had a… limited talk with it there. As I saw it, things were just as I had guessed before: it doesn’t have a complete mind and memory like you.”

Goathead finally caught up. It had never imagined that, in the short time the captain had gone back to his room for a ‘nap,’ he had already made another trip into Subspace. The news he now brought back from ‘over there’ was even more shocking. Goathead turned its neck and looked at the head on the table. Only after a long time did it squeeze out a question: “Then… what did it say to you?”

As soon as it spoke, it seemed to regret it, and hurried to add: “Ah, if it is the kind of ‘knowledge’ that is not very safe, then forget it. My curiosity is really not that…”

“It knows some things about ‘Duncan Abnomar,’ about as much as you do. To a degree, you should share the same ‘initial memories.’ But that part is not something we should talk about on this ship. It is enough that we understand each other,” Duncan waved his hand with a calm face. “You know what I mean.”

Goathead’s mouth snapped shut at once.

Of course it knew what the captain was talking about.

But that topic must never be brought up aboard the Vanished—this ship would be sunk by that “truth.” Without “Captain Duncan” as an anchor, it would fall back into Subspace once more.

This was the “unspoken agreement” that had formed between them after a period of sailing together, built through many hints and careful cooperation on both sides.

The captain’s cabin grew quiet. Duncan sat in his chair and rested, slowly gathering his strength again. The Dream-Skull lay motionless on the table. Its empty eye sockets stared at nothing. Goathead seemed to be deep in thought as well. No one knew what this “First Mate” was thinking about. Only after a long time did it suddenly raise its head: “Aside from that, you also…”

“The Pale giant King,” Duncan said. “The creator mentioned in The Blasphemous Tome, the one from the first Long Night. Its corpse has fused with the creation wreckage from that Long Night… but I can’t say more than that. It could be harmful.”

Goathead stiffened for a moment, then slowly lowered its head: “All right. I won’t ask.”

Duncan answered with a quiet “mm.” He did not speak again, but sank into memory and thought.

Even though he knew idle thinking could not give him any useful conclusion right now, he could not stop his mind from turning to those “fragments” that had poured into his head, and to the voice that had spoken to him in that roar.

Even broken as they were, he could still draw a lot from those words—

They were a race that had almost cracked the Truth of all things.

A civilization that already stood at the peak of time and space.

They called themselves “humans”—yet they were clearly very different from the “humans” Zhou Ming knew in the year 2022.

They had walked the path of civilization for too long, and had almost reached the end of the Truth.

Yet they also met their end on the day of the Great Annihilation. Unlike other destroyed peoples in other worlds, they might have been the only civilization with the power and chance to observe the Great Annihilation in full and prepare for it.

Even though they still could not stop the Great Annihilation from coming, it seemed they had found some way to preserve one complete… “seed” at the moment of Universal Extinction.

Duncan turned his head and calmly set his gaze on the oval antique mirror hanging on the nearby wall, on the figure reflected within.

Now he finally knew why there was no red light that stood for the destruction of all things in “his own memories”—because the Great Annihilation had not taken place in the era he knew.

The Great Annihilation lay in a far-off future.

But compared to these possible “truths,” an even bigger question filled his heart.

Why did there have to be a “Zhou Ming”?

He sat behind the table and thought, thought for a very long time. At last, he forced himself to put all the worries in his head aside for the moment and walked to the door.

“I’m going to walk on deck.”

He said this to Goathead, then pushed the door open and left the captain’s cabin.

The deck was wide and quiet. The pale glow of the World’s Wound shone on the distant sea. The water was calm. Now and then small waves slapped the hull, but the sound was soft, not noisy at all.

Duncan walked slowly along the edge of the deck with no goal in mind. He no longer thought about those distant questions that were doomed to have no answer. It was as if he walked only to empty his head, only to feel the night wind.

He kept walking until he saw a slender figure appear not far ahead, and then he stopped.

Alice was sitting on a big barrel near the rail—that was her favorite barrel. She rocked her body gently on it as she looked out at the sea. Her lower legs swung back and forth, and she seemed to be humming some odd tune under her breath.

Duncan listened for a while and then realized that it was the sailor’s minor-key tune Goathead sometimes hummed. Goathead’s pitch was not very true to begin with, and now, after being “improved” by Alice, the tune had grown so crooked that probably only a handful of people on the whole Boundless Sea could still recognize it.

Yet in Alice’s humming, it still sounded pleasant.

The doll finally noticed Duncan approaching. She stopped at once, jumped happily down from the barrel, and called: “Captain!”

“Mm.” Duncan’s mouth curved in a small smile. “I came out for a walk.”

Alice blinked, then suddenly looked very seriously into Duncan’s eyes.

“You look a bit tired. Do you have something on your mind? Is there another big problem you have to deal with?”

The doll’s sharpness took him by surprise, and he froze for a moment. Soon he smiled and shook his head: “It’s nothing. I just happened to be thinking about something. Why are you still not asleep this late? Do you have something on your mind too?”

“No,” Alice answered with a bright grin. “I’m just a bit happy, so I can’t sleep.”

“Happy?”

Alice jumped into an excited explanation at once: “I sent all the ‘spoils’ to the kitchen! They’re very useful—the ‘friends’ in the kitchen didn’t seem very happy at first, but after I explained, they accepted those ‘new friends’…

“I also checked the meat we salted before. It’s in great shape! This time not even a single barrel spoiled. In about a month we can use it for cooking…

“I pickled some cucumbers too. Nina taught me. She said pickles go with smoked meat patties, and they’re much better than the way Goathead taught me…

“I also found a big bunch of never-used pencils in the storage room at the stern of the second deck. I don’t know who put them there. I’m going to use them for drawing. Lunie is really good at drawing. She said she can teach me, but we have to wait until she has time…”

The doll went on like this, talking happily about all kinds of small things, things so tiny they hardly counted as “good news” at all. Yet she truly found great joy in these little matters. Each one made her excited—and now she was doing her best to pull out that joy and share it, hoping to make the captain a bit happier too.

Even though she had no idea what the captain usually worried about or thought about.

Duncan did not interrupt her. He only listened quietly, and he listened for a long time, until a real smile returned to the depths of his eyes.

Alice finally stopped, blinking in the night as she looked at Duncan with simple, bright happiness.

“Alice, have you ever thought about your own ‘birth’?” Duncan asked after a moment. “Have you ever wondered why you came into being, and why you think? Why you are ‘Alice,’ and what ‘Alice’s’ future will be? Have you ever thought about questions like that?”

“No!” Alice answered without even a second of hesitation. Questions that could keep philosophers busy for a whole lifetime were, to her, simple to the extreme—she never thought about them. “Never!”

But as soon as she said it, she seemed to feel that her answer sounded a bit careless. She hesitated and added: “Is that a bad answer? Does it make me seem a bit silly? Do you usually think about these things, Captain?”

Duncan looked at the doll, half amused, half helpless.

Then he laughed and slowly shook his head: “You answered very well.”

Alice did not understand why.

Duncan did not explain. He simply reached out and gently pressed his hand over the doll’s hair.

“If you want to draw, I can teach you.”

“Captain, you know how to draw?”

“A little. A very long time ago… Do you want to learn?”

“Yes!”

Chapter 670: A Gloomy Future

At 99 Crown Street in Lightwind Harbor, inside the Witch residence.

Shirley lay bored over the windowsill, staring blankly at the street outside.

Peace and order had already returned to this city-state. Although many people were still troubled by the Dream After-Effect, the physical damage this Lightwind Harbor incident had caused was clearly far less than in Pland and Frostholm. At least, in the parts of the city one could see, most people's daily lives had already gone back to the tracks they knew.

Some children ran cheering through a crossroads where the blockade had been lifted, holding colorful pinwheels as they dashed along the street in the bright sunlight.

It was close to noon. Vision 001 hung high in the sky. Many pretty blue rooftops across the street were bathing in the sunlight. Now and then, Shirley could see members of the Knowledge Guard in Guardian uniforms standing on high spots, watching the neighborhood with wary, serious eyes.

"Yawn…" Shirley stretched in a long, lazy way, then turned her head and glanced at Nina beside her. "What have you been doing since early morning?"

Nina sat behind a small table near the window, head lowered, gripping a pen and sketching in a big notebook. Her other hand held a glowing little "fireball", which she sometimes raised to her mouth to take a small bite. She did not even lift her head when she heard Shirley: "Mechanical design. I'll take it to the custom workshop later…"

Shirley listened in a daze. She could not help leaning over to look at the dizzying gears and linkages on Nina's pages. She stared at this friend who loved to study, full of confusion: "…Didn't the Old Gentleman say he wrote to Pland to help you drop out of school? You don't have to take exams anymore, so why are you still working so hard?"

Nina immediately lifted her head and looked at Shirley with a very serious face: "It wasn't dropping out. It was early graduation. I didn't have much to do on the ship, so I finished all the high school courses. Teacher Morris talked it over with Uncle Duncan. They said there wasn't much point in me going back to school like this, and the normal path for people doesn't really suit me, so they handled an early graduation for me…"

Shirley was dumbfounded: "You can do that?"

"Normal people can't, but Teacher Morris vouched for me. He can," Nina said. She picked up the little Sun in her hand and took another bite. She chewed with a crunching sound and mumbled: "And I think it's pretty good. I didn't have many friends at school anyway, and I've been following Uncle Duncan on adventures outside for so long. I probably wouldn't fit in if I went back…"

Shirley did not even notice what Nina said at the end. From the middle on, her attention had already fallen on that little "fireball" Nina was gnawing on. She held back for a long time, then finally could not help blurting out: "You've been chewing on this all day… Is that thing tasty?"

Nina casually handed the little Sun over: "Do you want to try?"

Shirley jumped back two meters at once: "I haven't lived enough yet!"

"It's actually not hot at all…" Nina sulked a little as she pulled the little Sun back and muttered: "What a pity. I even wanted to ask Miss Vanna to try it earlier, and she turned me down too…"

“Anyone with a normal brain would never accept that. Honestly, the scariest part is that you can really use this as a snack,” Shirley said. She kept a safe distance from Nina and looked at the fireball in Nina’s hand with a strange expression. “You just eat it like this… Are you really okay? The captain and the Old Gentleman really let you do this?”

“Yeah. After they confirmed it didn’t have any bad effect on me, Teacher Morris even encouraged me to keep ‘testing’ and ‘observing’ it,” Nina nodded and said. “He said my ‘devouring’ process of this Sun might reveal the transformations and compatibility between certain fragments of the Old World, and might even help find a way to solve the chaos at the base of all things… I don’t really understand the details, but he and Uncle Duncan talked about it for a long time.”

As she spoke, she lifted the little Sun again and took another small bite: “The things they discuss have been getting more and more advanced lately. This morning, after Uncle came back from the ship, they discussed for another two hours. I even heard them say they should find a way to capture another Ender to study, and they were talking about where to go catch one…”

Shirley’s face changed halfway through listening. She turned to look toward the living room not far away.

Duncan and Morris were sitting on the sofa in the living room. In fact, their discussion had been going on in fits and starts the whole time and had not ended yet.

Alice was sprawled beside Duncan at the coffee table. She held a pencil and was totally focused on doodling her “drawing” on a sheet of white paper.

“…We have never been this close to the ‘truth’ of the world’s origin. The ‘impact’ we observed in the deepest part of Atlantis’s memory is so far the only ‘event’ that can explain the Great Annihilation… I have been in

contact with my mentor since yesterday. As far as I know, he has already shared this information with the other three popes…”

Morris spoke with a very serious face. In his hand, he absent-mindedly played with an exquisite crystal prismatic lens. sunlight from the window fell on the lens and kept refracting into all kinds of bright colors in his hand.

Duncan slowly nodded: “The Great Annihilation brought deadly chaos and conflict, and that chaos and conflict is still rooted in the essence of all things… The third Long Night did not solve that underlying clash. It only delayed its outbreak. Now it seems that this ‘delay’ has reached its limit. The coming of ‘dusk’ really cannot be avoided.”

“The key question now is what will happen after ‘dusk’ arrives, and in what form this so-called ‘fourth Long Night’ will come and end,” Morris said, his tone full of worry. “One obvious fact is that no matter what, our current ‘Deep Sea era’ will go through drastic change in that process. The city-states on the Boundless Sea… may be wiped out just like in the first two Long Nights.”

He suddenly stopped. After a few seconds of silence, he shook his head: “Or even worse.”

Duncan did not answer. Once the topic stretched to the coming “dusk”, the scene he had seen in Subspace rose in his mind on its own.

The ancient Elder Kings had circled around the pale giants who had died at creation, holding a funeral for an Elder God amid a dim Doomsday.

If every “Long Night” had to match a “dusk”, then the reflection he had seen in the giant’s single eye was the scene at dusk.

He also thought of that spreading starlight, and the roar that had come from deep within the stars.

After he had stayed silent for who knew how long, he finally spoke softly: “Maybe only the ‘Elder Kings’ can really answer my questions.”

Morris looked up in surprise: “What did you say?”

Duncan shook his head and did not answer. After thinking for a moment, he changed the subject: “From the information we have now, whether they are Annihilators or the Sunspawn of the Sun, they are all making preparations for the coming ‘dusk’. The word those Annihilators mention the most is ‘a new place’—in the next era after the Deep Sea era, they want to take a place in advance.”

“That may match the idea of ‘the abandoned races’ in the third Long Night,” Morris said at once with a nod. “Based on the evidence you recently found, not all ‘races’ could coexist after the Genesis Protocol. Many races were left outside the Sanctuary World during the third Long Night. The Black Sun may have been only one of them. Many more abandoned races probably did not even leave behind a single scrap of information…”

He paused a little here, seeming to fall into thought, then went on: “And if we start from the idea that ‘the basis of all things is conflict and destruction’, and add the condition that ‘the Gods build the next era on the world’s Embers’, then the coming fourth Long Night may mean building the next era on the Embers of the Deep Sea era. The most likely result is…”

Morris hesitated, but Duncan had already finished the words he had not said: “The next era will be a ‘Sanctuary World’ even narrower, tighter, and more crowded than the Deep Sea era.”

The living room fell into a brief silence. Only the soft scratching of Alice’s pencil on paper went on. The doll did not care about the questions she could not understand. She was just lost in her own “creation”, still full of interest.

After a minute or two, Morris finally slowly put down the prism in his hand.

“More ‘races’ will be abandoned. More creations of civilization will turn into the next era’s ‘Blasphemous Archetypes’. They will be destroyed, exiled, not allowed to stay in the Mortal Realm dimension, not even allowed to stay in the records of history. Many things we value in this era will become the next era’s corruption and taboo, just like the Sun’s Remnant Folk who were abandoned in the last era…”

Duncan nodded lightly: “So those cultists are making their preparations, hoping to secure a place to live in that next, even narrower ‘world’, or at least a ‘spot’ that will not be wiped out so easily. Stealing the power or remains of the Elder Gods is the method they have thought of—though whether it will really work is very doubtful.”

“But what happens after that? Will there be a fifth Long Night, a sixth Long Night? This cycle may keep going, and even speed up, until some limit is reached. And in that process… the ‘Sanctuary World’ will keep getting smaller and more cramped…”

Morris’s thoughts kept spreading out. In the end he was almost talking to himself, describing the ending he had worked out from his dark, pessimistic reasoning.

Embers could reignite, but any rekindling had a limit. A fire that kept shrinking could only ever warm fewer people than before, until the fuel ran out and all things fell into eternal silence in the cold.

In the next era, there might no longer be the Boundless Sea. The last place for civilization to live might be only a single city. After that, it might be only a town, a neighborhood, a single house, a small rock floating in the void. The last faint, muddled strand of “civilization’s” reason would cling to

that stone, recalling the glow of past civilizations in a dull, witless daze, and then die in its last dreamlike murmur as its mind faded.

That would be the true end of all things.

Chapter 671: News of the Gathering

Morris's guess pointed to a dark future where all things were silent forever. The chill it brought was far worse than any strange, shocking prophecy of destruction, far worse than the Doomsday calamity muttered by madmen.

It was a dark and icy extinction. The last firelight would slowly go out in civilization's Embers. The afterglow of civilization would be choked bit by bit in wave after wave of deadly shrinking, like a ship that was slowly sinking. In despair, people would throw weight off the ship again and again to try to delay its fate, but in the end, every plank of the ship would still fall into that endless dark abyss of sea.

What was even harder to accept was that, judging from the information they had, the chance of this future was very high. It might even be the best of all the possibilities.

Because at least "civilization" would still have a chance to cling to life for a while after the fourth and fifth Long Nights. At least it could still enjoy a little last, false peace in that Sanctuary World that kept shrinking and collapsing.

In a worse case, there might not be that many later Long Nights at all. The third Long Night had already been a once-only "sacred miracle" and "stroke of luck". The coming dusk would be the day of the true end of all things.

[…Maybe that would be a better outcome?]

All kinds of thoughts rose and fell in his mind. At last, Duncan shook his head and pushed these messy ideas aside for now: “We’ve fallen into pessimism, Morris.”

“We have. Making these guesses when we still don’t know when or in what form the fourth Long Night will come… is a bit early,” Morris said. He rubbed his brow and finally pulled himself free from that gloomy mood. “My mentor is putting together a ‘gathering’ that will span the four great churches. You will be invited to that gathering. At least by then, we should be able to exchange more and better information. The popes of the Four Gods also need the truths we have.”

Duncan gave a small nod. He was not surprised by this news, because it was one of the “agreements” he had already made with Pope Rune of Truth.

If anything, he was a little curious how that elven old man had persuaded the popes of the other Three Gods to accept this “proposal”. Pope Helena of the Deep Sea was easier to talk about. Duncan had dealt with her in Pland, and he also had a link through Vanna, the “secret envoy”. That pope was more or less a leader who was neutral but leaned friendly. But the other two…

Frem, the head of the Flamebearer Church, might be interested in the “Chronicle Pillar” in Vanna’s hand. And what about Banster of the Church of Death?

Duncan’s expression shifted subtly a few times. Then he raised his hand and tapped the pocket mirror on the coffee table: “Agatha.”

Agatha’s figure almost instantly appeared in the mirror: “I’m here.”

“…Are you close with Banster?”

“In ‘my’ memories, there was a time when I received guidance from His Holiness the pope and trained on the ‘Graveyard Ark’,” Agatha said after

thinking for a moment, not sounding very sure. “But that is far from really being familiar. There are many Saints on the Boundless Sea. I’m not as ‘special’ as Miss Vanna.”

Duncan rubbed his chin, thoughtful: “…Then you probably don’t really know whether Banster cares a lot about that frigate from back then…”

“He cares a lot.”

Duncan: “…”

He had not even finished his sentence!

“He cares a lot,” Agatha repeated. Then, as if she was afraid Duncan would not believe her, she carefully explained: “Even someone as obscure as me would hear him sigh over that beautiful frigate every now and then.”

Duncan: “…”

“Of course, His Holiness the pope sometimes tries to seem more generous,” Agatha went on, recalling. “He usually starts by saying ‘Actually, I don’t mind that much’, then sighs for a while, and in the end he finishes with ‘It’s just a pity. I designed it myself… Of course I don’t really mind.’”

Duncan almost lost his straight face: “…Isn’t that exactly really minding it?!”

“Ahem.” At this point, Morris suddenly coughed twice at the side, cutting off the increasingly odd rhythm of Duncan and Agatha’s talk. “I think that compared to that famous frigate the Ephemeral, the Viseran Thirteen Isles will be an even more sensitive topic at the gathering.”

“In fact… the Viseran Thirteen Isles may not be that sensitive,” Agatha shook her head instead. “Even though it was a greater loss, inside the Church of Death there are some priests who tend to treat it as a ‘Subspace disaster’. They think that what caused that disaster was the Dimensional

Collapse Phenomenon rather than the Vanished. The Vanished only fell into Subspace together with the thirteen isles. It's like a big fire where two people are dragged into the flames together. We can't say that the person who climbed back out of the fire is the arsonist.

"This explanation did not appear out of thin air. Many academic studies on the 'Border Collapse Phenomenon' support it.

"Of course, this explanation is quite controversial inside the Church. For obvious reasons, the bishops don't like this interpretation that 'defends the Vanished'. But since His Holiness the pope has already accepted the invitation to the gathering, I believe he is ready to use this explanation to define what happened back then… or at least to steady the bishops' attitude.

"By comparison, the 'Ephemeral incident' really was a… direct, undeniable attack. The Vanished took that ship away right in front of the fleet."

Morris suddenly understood: "So that's how it is…"

Duncan then reacted: "Wait, that ship really was called 'the Ephemeral'? That wasn't just a nickname people gave it after the incident?"

Agatha and Morris both nodded quietly.

Duncan's expression turned strange: "…Why would you give a ship such an unlucky name?"

"…It's the Church of Death's naming tradition for warships. In fact, it's our tradition when we name many things. For example, the main battleship called 'Wrongful Death', and the long-barreled cannon model 'Sudden Passing'," Agatha said with a calm face. "We see death and passing as a necessary part of the workings of the mortal world. Words related to them are not really taboo for us. And strictly speaking, the name 'the Vanished' isn't very 'lucky' either, is it?"

Duncan thought about it and felt that the Gatekeeper was right.

Just then, Alice suddenly looked up, cutting off the exchange between Duncan and Agatha: “Captain, I finished my drawing!”

Even Agatha in the mirror was startled by the sudden noise. Duncan could not help looking at the doll with a rather odd expression.

Alice had had her head down drawing this whole time, as if all the talk and discussion happening around her belonged to another world. Now that she had finished her “creation”, she wanted to show her work to the captain without any worry or second thought.

For a moment, Duncan even felt a little jealous of the doll’s good mood.

Alice happily pushed the drawing over to Duncan.

It was a… clumsy piece of art.

At a glance you could see how unpracticed the artist was. You could even see that the artist was not even used to holding a pencil. There was no talk of any technique at all, let alone beauty or composition.

On it was a very big and very abstract ship. Dark pencil marks outlined the sails and ripples of the water. A few little stick figures with arms stretched out were standing on the deck. The strokes were a mess, but you could still barely tell the people of the Vanished apart—

Vanna was very tall. Morris had a pipe in his mouth. Shirley and Dog were together. Nina had little flames on her head. Agatha was a dark shadow. Ai perched on the mast. Goathead was sticking his head out of the captain’s cabin window…

Duncan stood on the highest spot wearing a captain’s hat. He was clearly drawn with more care, but was still crooked.

Other than Duncan, each “person” on the ship had lines trailing off from their bodies, drifting and curling in the air.

Morris leaned over curiously for a look, and his expression turned a bit odd: “Uh… As a first ‘drawing’ it’s actually… not that bad. But in general, you can’t see lines on people… At least you don’t need to show them when you draw.”

The old mister’s comment was very gentle, but Alice clearly had her own view: “But they’re really there.”

Morris looked a bit helpless. He raised his head to look at Duncan, and Duncan just started laughing.

“They are there,” Duncan said with a smile. His gaze rested on Alice’s first “masterpiece”, and slowly, a thoughtful look appeared in his eyes. “…This is the world in her eyes.”

“Right?” Alice said at once in pride. “So I didn’t draw it wrong!”

“But…” Duncan noticed another problem. “Why aren’t you in the picture?”

Alice froze at that. She looked down at the Vanished she had drawn and answered: “Because I’m the one drawing.”

Duncan thought it over and finally understood the doll’s logic.

He did not know whether to laugh or cry, and also found it a bit funny.

“The person drawing can still draw themselves into the picture—I’ll help you add you.”

As he spoke, he picked up the pencil Alice had left at the side. With a few swift strokes he drew Alice’s simple figure onto the Vanished, putting her beside himself.

Alice watched with wide eyes and gave a happy cry: “Wow! Captain, you draw much better than me!”

Duncan only smiled at that. He set the pencil down and carefully rolled up the drawing, then put it into Alice's hands.

"Keep it safe. This is your first 'work'."

Alice looked especially happy: "Okay!"

Duncan then turned his head and looked toward an empty spot in the living room: "Is everything taken care of?"

Almost as soon as he finished speaking, Lucretia's figure suddenly appeared in the air amid a burst of fluttering colorful paper pieces.

"Don't worry, Dad, it's all handled."

Chapter 672: Ted Riel’s Visit

Lucretia brought that creepy stuffed rabbit doll over to Duncan. She sat down on the sofa beside him, while Rabby carefully shuffled over to the side of the sofa and plopped onto the floor with a soft “thump”.

“I already sent that Saint to the containment room on the Radiant Star. There are sealing facilities there made specifically to deal with corrupted things from the border and the Spirit Realm. He will slowly recover there until he can meet your needs for the ritual.

“The surviving sacrificial victims have been placed in the city’s relief center. I have spoken with Sara Mell. Lightwind Harbor will take good care of them and try to send them back home if possible… Some of them have lost their sanity and their memories. They cannot even say where their homes are, so a psychiatrist will step in later to help.

“As you ordered, I left the artificial beacon on that ship. You should now be able to sense the ship’s condition through the beacon…

“In addition, I checked all the supplies on that ship that are still usable. There are many. We can bring them back later when we have the chance—consider it a generous haul of spoils. After all, a self-sailing ghost ship has no use for fuel or spare mechanical parts…”

Lucretia reported everything to Duncan point by point. She was clear and organized, and all her arrangements were proper.

Clearly, she was very familiar with this kind of cleanup work.

“Mm.” Duncan nodded in satisfaction and did not hold back his praise: “You did very well.”

But Lucretia parted her lips and suddenly looked a little hesitant.

Duncan noticed it and asked: “Is there anything else?”

“…I told Brother what happened here. He asked whether we needed a fleet,” Lucretia said. “Considering that the Annihilators’ ‘nest’ might be a sea fortress that has been running for centuries or even longer, and that it lies in the border fog, we may need a real ‘offensive’ next. He said that if necessary, he can send the Sea Mist fleet over.”

“That is not necessary,” Duncan thought for a moment, then still shook his head. “At least not for now. We still do not know what that nest looks like. If we expand our operation too soon, it might backfire… We should first scout out the situation in the fog.”

“Alright.” Lucretia nodded.

At that moment, a presence that suddenly appeared outside the house interrupted the conversation in the living room.

Lucretia frowned and looked toward the entryway. Almost at the same second, the doorbell rang from that direction.

Lunie, who had been standing in the corner of the living room on standby, immediately got up and walked to the front door. Lucretia quickly instructed: “No newspapers, no insurance, no lottery tickets, no community surveys. If they say they are raising money for the neighborhood, send them away at once. There was a notice last month. That bunch are all scammers —I really don’t get how anyone still dares to come here…”

“Mistress.” Before Lucretia finished, Lunie was already back in the living room. “It is His Excellency the Truth Keeper.”

“…Uh?” Lucretia blurted.

In the moment she froze, a helpless voice already came from the doorway: “I know Miss Witch never likes people dropping by, but the situation really is special this time—there is an invitation from the Four Gods Church I need to deliver to your father.”

Along with that tired and helpless voice, Ted Riel stepped into the living room. The Truth Keeper looked the same as always. The air around him carried the aura of someone who had worked overtime for a whole month without a single day off.

“Under normal circumstances, no one would dare come near your witch’s manor. Taran Ael’s lumbar spine flared up today and he cannot get out of bed, so I had to come in person.”

As he finished speaking, Ted Riel noticed Duncan sitting on the sofa and immediately showed a slight smile: “Good day, Captain.”

“Taran Ael can finally lie down for a few days,” Lucretia said casually after hearing Ted’s news. “I even think that’s a good thing.”

“Not for me. I lost three sola on it,” Ted Riel said with some regret. “A few colleagues at the academy and I placed bets on which part of Taran’s body would fail first this time, and I lost badly… For the record, I bet on hemorrhoids.”

Lucretia’s expression turned a bit odd. “You people are really bored…”

Ted Riel shrugged. “But I guessed right several times before.”

Morris, who had been sitting on the sofa, now stood up and greeted the Truth Keeper: “Ted, have you recovered?”

“It was just a bit of indigestion—it did not affect me as much as those papers the brats rushed out overnight,” Ted Riel waved a hand. Then his

gaze stopped on Morris without him realizing it. He looked Morris over for several seconds, puzzled and a little stunned, before finally speaking with a strange expression: “We met in a hurry last time, so I did not have time to look carefully. Morris, your…”

He suddenly stopped. After a brief hesitation, he seemed to understand something and let out a quiet breath.

“Nothing. You look quite energetic.”

“Really? I also feel that my condition is very good now. My daughter is a psychiatrist, and she also thinks my mindset is very healthy.” Morris smiled. His eyes behind the blessed monocle were as bright as ever, and his smile carried a gentle, scholarly warmth.

Only Saints and Scholars with exceptionally strong Spiritual Insight could sense, from his smile, his gaze, and his voice, the almost unnoticeable madness and noise that had long drifted away from human reason.

Ted Riel took his eyes off Morris and looked at Duncan.

Many, many years ago, he and this man, the greatest explorer in history, had been friends.

For an elf, forming a friendship with humans was something that required great caution and a lot of mental preparation.

But back then, Ted Riel could never have imagined that all his mental preparation had gone in the wrong direction—he should not have been worrying about saying farewell to short-lived humans, but about meeting again with an immortal subspace shadow.

Fortunately, the light of humanity still shone within this shadow—though that light was filled with truths he did not dare to peer into and echoed with noise he did not dare to hear.

“I was just discussing matters of the Four Gods Church with Morris,” Duncan took the initiative to speak. “I knew there would be a gathering, but I did not expect the official notice to arrive so quickly.”

Ted Riel fell silent for a moment. He took a finely sealed letter, stamped with wax, from his coat, set it on the coffee table, and pushed it toward Duncan.

“I am not sure whether you care about something like an ‘invitation letter’, but the Academy Ark told me to give this to you,” he said. “It already bears the signatures of the Four Gods’ popes. You can see it as the Four Gods Church’s first official and formal gesture of goodwill toward the Vanished Fleet.”

Duncan’s gaze fell on the beautifully sealed letter. He reached out, opened it, and took out the special “invitation” inside.

On the stiff card, neat handwriting stated that the Four Gods Church would hold a “special closed meeting”, and it extended an invitation to “the master of the Vanished Fleet”, “Captain Duncan the great explorer”. The content itself was nothing remarkable. Only the four shining signatures at the end of the invitation strongly drew Duncan’s eyes.

They were as dazzling as arcs of electricity burning in the dark—Rahm, Tarrigan, Gamona, Bartok.

Duncan calmly looked at those names and actually did not feel surprised at all.

“It says here the meeting will be held tomorrow—that soon?” He put away the invitation and spoke casually.

“Yes. At least judging from Your Eminence Rune’s attitude, the sooner this gathering is held, the better,” Ted Riel nodded. “Before noon tomorrow, the

Four Gods Church's fleets will arrive one after another near Lightwind Harbor. All the Pilgrimage Arks will appear—that will be a grand event."

At this, Duncan paused in surprise. Beside him, Morris let out an involuntary gasp: "Ah? You mean the gathering will be held in the Mortal Realm, and the four popes will gather here?"

"Yes. At first I also thought it would be a 'meeting' held through Psychic Resonance, like the gatherings the popes and Saints held in the past. I did not expect the meeting to take place in the Mortal Realm, much less that it would be… tomorrow."

"For such an important 'closed meeting', this is almost the same as having no preparation at all, and the Pilgrimage Arks themselves need time to sail…" Duncan seemed to have thought of something. "So the most reasonable answer is that the four Pilgrimage Arks had already been moving to the southern border beforehand. Even before the Lightwind Harbor incident, the Four Gods Church might already have planned a gathering. What happened in Lightwind Harbor just gave them an unexpected chance to hold it here and set it for tomorrow?"

"It seems so."

"…Has something happened recently? Is it related to the Church's frequent activities in the border seas these days, and those fleets being gathered near the Eternal Veil?"

"I know about the situations you just mentioned, but I do not know the inside story."

Duncan was a bit surprised. "Even you, the Truth Keeper, do not know about these things?"

"I truly do not know," Ted Riel shook his head. "The Truth Keeper, the Inquisitors, the Gatekeepers, and the Firekeepers may all be the city's

highest Church representatives in name, but what we handle is only city affairs. The four Pilgrimage Arks actually operate independently of the entire Church system. The four popes command those arks directly. All the ‘secrets’ are sealed within the ark fleets and do not interact with the cities or with how the Church runs between cities—especially… the more dangerous secrets.”

He raised his head and looked into Duncan’s eyes very seriously.

“It is a necessary safety measure.”

Chapter 673: They Were “Communicating”

For Lightwind Harbor, which had just woken safely from a nightmare, the collective visit of the four Pilgrimage Arks felt like another strange and bizarre dream. It all happened too suddenly. Even the scholars of the Truth Academy and the governor seemed to receive word only when the arks were about to arrive. So even when the Deep Sea Church’s Storm Cathedral appeared on the sea horizon, the citizens of Lightwind Harbor still felt as if it were unreal.

The Cathedral ships of the Four Gods had truly arrived.

Aside from the Academy Ark, which had been moored beside Lightwind Harbor ever since the “Nameless One’s Dream” incident, the first to arrive was the temple of the storm goddess Gamona. The Storm Cathedral reached them at dawn that day. When Vision 001’s radiant halo pierced the sky, the huge pilgrimage temple emerged from a bank of condensed fog onto the sea surface. It and its escort fleet approached from the western side of the city and moored along the coast when the morning bell rang for the third time.

After that came the Flamebearer’s Cathedral ship. The “Flamebearer Temple” surfaced on the sea along with Vision 001’s rising glow, as if sunlight from a blazing sun had fallen into the mortal world. It sailed out of a mirage that looked like flaming sunlight and docked between the Storm Cathedral and the Academy Ark.

Death god Bartok's Cathedral ship arrived last. The "Death Sanctuary" appeared from a bank of dark, dense fog with solemn bells ringing. Its vast shadow swelled and grew in the mist, like a huge graveyard entering the Mortal Realm from the land of the dead. It and its two escort sister ships —"Closed Eye" and "Unclosed Eye"—moored beside the Storm Cathedral.

Those four Cathedral arks, each as huge as a small city-state, almost "surrounded" Lightwind Harbor. If part of their escort fleets had not been left out on the nearby sea in advance, their full escort ships would have nearly crowded out every stretch of shoreline around Lightwind Harbor. If a pair of eyes with nearsightedness and astigmatism had looked down from the sky just then, they might even have confused Lightwind Harbor with the neighboring Pilgrimage Arks and seen them all as one giant, continuous cross-shaped island.

The city's City Hall issued a temporary order in the morning to seal the harbor and ban near-shore sailing. The Truth Academy announced that the four great Churches would temporarily hold a "special closed meeting" in Lightwind Harbor.

After that, curious citizens gathered near different parts of the harbor. They fought to claim good spots so they could get a look at the Cathedral ships' grand shapes. After all, the Cathedral arks usually sailed along secret routes on the Boundless Sea. Ordinary people almost never saw them. This time they had not only appeared near the city, but all four arks had shown up together. Even elves, with their long lifespans, might not see such a sight many times in a lifetime.

On the tallest tower of the city academy near the western coast, Duncan was standing on a balcony, looking toward the shoreline.

He had nothing else to do anyway, so he stood there watching each Church's Cathedral ship appear one by one. The sight was quite spectacular.

“Your Cathedral arks really all have their own special tricks,” he sighed casually.

“To move such massive ‘ships’ quickly across the sea, the power of steam engines alone is not enough,” Ted Riel stood beside Duncan on the high tower balcony, enjoying the wind as he explained. “Each Cathedral ark is both a ship and an supernatural item. Those huge cathedrals and academies on them are not just decoration. They draw the Gods’ power into the Mortal Realm and give the arks all kinds of unbelievable traits. They can race through storms, pass through mist and flame, or become invisible to mortal eyes and calm the tempests of the sea…”

Duncan turned his head with some curiosity. “Then what ‘sacred miracle’ does the Truth Academy’s Academy Ship rely on to sail so fast?”

“…Outstanding engineering. We built two hundred and sixty engine arrays. With enough power, even bricks can fly.”

Duncan: “…?”

“To make machines run, to make theory work, to make paradoxes hold—that in itself is part of Rahm’s sacred miracle,” Ted Riel clearly saw the odd look on Duncan’s face and could not help laughing. “The same engine arrays would not even start on other Cathedral ships. If they did not blow up on the spot, that would already show their craftsmanship is excellent.”

“…The Gods’ sacred miracles are truly unbelievable.”

Duncan shook his head with a subtle expression. After sighing under his breath, he turned his gaze and looked toward the distant shoreline.

He had seen the Deep Sea Church’s Storm Cathedral and the Truth Academy’s Academy Ark before. But this was the first time he had seen the Death God’s Death Sanctuary and Flamebearer Temple. Just like the other two Cathedral ships, these two Pilgrimage Arks had very distinct styles.

Flamebearer Temple gave people an ancient, solemn feeling. Gray-white stone buildings of different heights spread across the massive ark base. Those solemn and mysterious structures were totally unlike the styles found in modern city-states. They looked more like “ancient temples” restored straight out of some historical paintings. The most striking structure stood at the center of the complex: a huge high platform, encircled by solemn stone pillars. A ring of blazing flames burned around the top of the platform. At the center of that fire stood a strangely shaped giant pillar. That pillar looked very much like the Gatekeeper’s cane that Vanna had received from Tarrigan. It was obviously the Chronicle Pillar worshiped by the Flamebearers.

The Death Sanctuary was much gloomier. Black-toned Brother-style buildings were the most common “scenery” on that ark. Its core facility was a pitch-black temple shaped like a great pyramid. The temple sat on a high ground in the center of the ark, surrounded by tall towers, and it gave off a grave-like heaviness. At first sight, Duncan understood why many people simply called the Death God’s Pilgrimage Ark “the Great Graveyard”. It really did look the part.

No matter which ark he looked at, Duncan saw illusory projections floating above them in the air, like spirit forms that normal eyes could not see.

He lifted his head and, face calm as still water, used his gaze on those “spirit forms floating over the mortal world”.

Smoke-like and mist-like, tentacle-shaped phantom limbs spread out from those spirit form projections. They drifted silently over all of Lightwind Harbor like hazy Restless Souls. They did not disturb one another, but sometimes a phantom “tentacle” would suddenly stretch out from its own “body” to touch a tentacle stretching out from another ark—

Duncan noticed this “contact”. He instinctively felt that these hurried touches were not coincidences but something intentional.

He even felt that some of those phantom tentacles were practically… giving each other high-fives.

Some spirit forms drifting over from the harbor floated near the academy’s tall tower and circled around the balcony.

Duncan hesitated for a moment. He glanced back at Ted Riel, who did not seem to be paying attention here, then quietly rubbed his fingers together.

A wisp of spirit form flame appeared in the air and quietly touched those Spirits of the Ark drifting there, which mortal eyes could not see.

In careful perception, he touched the “thoughts” that flowed between those spirits.

Some strange, deep noises echoed in Duncan’s mind. Then, inside those strange, deep noises, actual understandable messages appeared. He heard whispers that did not sound like humans vibrating through time and space… They were “communicating”!

That vibration went deep into his consciousness—

“…The weather is nice.”

“It is okay. This place is really hot.”

“Better than up north. My tentacles were frozen stiff up there…”

“Didn’t you lose all your tentacles a long time ago?”

“Phantom limbs.”

“What are they going to talk about today?”

“How would I know—I just woke up.”

“…Huh? I also just woke up. What are they even going to talk about today?”

“…Stop asking. We all just woke up.”

Duncan: “…?”

Ted Riel finally noticed Duncan’s sudden subtle expression and, even more, the flicker of phantom flame that had flashed in the air. The Truth Keeper tensed up at once: “What happened?”

It would have been better if he had not asked. As soon as he did, Duncan’s expression became even stranger.

But before the Truth Keeper grew so nervous that his stomach acted up again, Duncan forced himself to get his expression under control and shoved that bizarre feeling in his mind aside. He kept his face as calm as he could, looked up at Ted Riel, and asked: “…Do the arks talk to one another?”

“The arks? Talk?” Ted Riel froze at the question. “What do you mean?”

The expression on the Truth Keeper’s face did not look fake. Duncan could tell at a glance that this was probably another special “secret” that only the inner circle knew. Remembering that even Vanna did not know many of the Storm Cathedral’s secrets, he decisively waved his hand. “You do not know, so it is fine.”

Ted Riel instinctively wanted to ask more, but just before he opened his mouth, a faint warning rose in his heart.

He wisely shut his mouth.

Duncan changed the subject at the right moment: “The Four Gods’ arks have all gathered. Where exactly will the meeting be held? Inside Lightwind Harbor?”

Ted Riel shook his head and began to explain patiently: “Lightwind Harbor is not suitable for the meeting. On one hand, a gathering like this might affect the ordinary people in the city. On the other hand, this meeting came up so suddenly that the city has not made any preparations. There is also the question of secrecy.

“The message I received said we should wait for further notice. This time, what we will discuss points straight at the Great Annihilation and already touches the foundation of the world. That means even an offhand remark from anyone at the gathering could cause unpredictable consequences. Even the popes, Your Eminences, must choose the meeting place very carefully—

“Right now they are each on their own arks, using psychic echo to commune with the Gods and seek revelation. The final meeting place will probably be chosen from among the four arks.”

Duncan waved a hand, unconcerned. “Alright, then I will wait patiently. I just hope it does not take too long.”

Ted Riel nodded. But in the next second, the Truth Keeper suddenly frowned. It was as if he had heard a voice coming from far away, and his expression turned strange at once.

“What is it?” Duncan noticed the change and asked curiously.

Ted Riel was silent for a few seconds, a trace of confusion in his eyes. “… On the Fifth Ark…”

Chapter 674: The Fifth Ark

In a boundless, chaotic darkness, the spirit projections of Helena, Rune, Banster, and Frem gathered together.

The four Popes had already finished all their discussions for the meeting, yet they still did not disperse. The final guidance sent down by the divine will left them uneasy and confused.

Just moments ago, when they were choosing the meeting place, the Four Gods had, in a rare move, sent down a strong sign at the same time. Even though that “sign” was still mixed with massive, chaotic noise, all four Pilgrimage Arks were clearly ruled out by the deities.

In the guidance They sent, Helena, Rune, and the others were asked to go to “the Fifth Ark”.

Helena lowered her head. In this dark space woven from Psychic Resonance, a mass of flame burned faintly in her field of vision. She used her gaze on that flame, and only after a long time did she speak carefully: “…the Fifth Ark… what does it make you think of?”

“What else could it be?” Rune shook his head. “The answer is obvious. Besides the four Cathedral Arks, there is only one ship here that could be called ‘the Fifth Ark’.”

“…To be honest, this is the first time in my life I’ve doubted the result of an oracle.” Banster hesitated for several seconds, then finally raised his head and said to the other three, “We did agree to invite that captain, but to hold this crucial gathering on ‘that ship’? That was never part of the plan. And

the will the Lord sent down this time feels a bit… strange, don't you think? We haven't heard such a clear and forceful voice in many years…"

"They are urging us on, Banster," Frem said in his deep, calm voice. "We all know that time is running out, and of course They know it too."

Helena tilted her head slightly and glanced at Banster. "You're not still hung up on what happened with the Ephemeral, are you?"

"Of course not." Banster shook his head at once. "So many years have passed. I don't really care about that ship anymore. I'm just being a bit cautious… Of course, that's only my personal feeling. It can't change the command we've received. The revelation about 'the Fifth Ark' has already been sent out with the divine will. In truth, we don't have any other choice."

In the dark space, the four Popes fell silent at the same time.

Helena lowered her head again and fixed her gaze on the illusory flame burning in her sight. She knew that deep down she shared the same caution, even the same doubts, as Banster. But she chose instead to trust the Storm Goddess's guidance without question.

In that long, wordless gaze, she seemed to see the illusory flame in her sight slowly rise and spread in silence. The shifting fire turned into a gentle sea. The tide rose and fell before her eyes, and a vast, ancient vision slowly walked out of the waves toward her.

The image of the Storm Goddess rose out of the darkness. Behind the Goddess floated an even vaster, even more unspeakable "reality". That overlapping, tangled presence reached out gently toward Helena. Helena felt more than one cold touch brush against her soul, coil around her mind, and whisper at her ear:

"While there is still time…"

The vision of the tide faded. The soft sound of waves vanished from her ears as well.

“Go and make preparations,” Helena said, raising her head and looking calmly at the others. “Tell the Bishops who are coming to the gathering. Tell the duty crews on the arks. Let them know about ‘the Fifth Ark’. Everyone needs time to adjust, but also tell them that the time for preparation is limited.”

“And don’t forget to teach them some basic facts about ‘that ship’,” Rune reminded them. “It’s not like the Cathedral ships everyone is used to. I don’t want anyone stepping onto ‘that ship’ and causing some embarrassing misunderstanding because they get spooked.”

“You won’t manage to cover everything. There are too many strange things on that ship. Even now, Vanna keeps telling me about new, unbelievable situations from time to time.” Helena waved her hand. “Just tell everyone coming to the gathering this: no matter what they see on that ship, even if they see someone boiling their own head in a pot, they are not to scream. Treat everything as a natural occurrence.”

“Before we talk any further, we should contact that captain first,” Frem added suddenly, after staying mostly quiet until now. “We went ahead and made his ship the meeting place all on our own, but we still haven’t asked the Master for his opinion.”

Rune nodded. “Of course. We also need to arrange the boarding process and how people will be transferred over. The meeting schedule might also need an urgent adjustment… With the venue set somewhere other than the four Pilgrimage Arks, a lot of things will no longer go according to plan.”

“So many things to do…” Helena sighed wearily. Before her voice even faded, she waved her hand and her figure slowly disappeared into the darkness. “I’ll contact my own Saint first…”

“I need to talk with my own student as well.” Rune spoke right after, and his figure faded as well.

Soon, only Banster and Frem were left in the dark space.

“See you again in the Mortal Realm.” Frem, who was like a giant of living stone, waved his hand, then turned and vanished into the depths of the darkness.

Banster shrugged.

“I really don’t care about it anymore… Why does no one believe me…”

…

“What?! They’re coming onto this ship? Those Popes and Bishops?!”

In the captain’s cabin of the Vanished, Goathead, who had been busy chatting with his other head, clearly jumped in shock when he saw Duncan suddenly return and heard the news he brought. “Did they take the wrong medicine?”

“Don’t look at me. I’m surprised too,” Duncan said casually, giving Goathead a glance. “But the news has been confirmed. It’s even the will of the Four Gods. The four Pilgrimage Arks are all ruled out. The final meeting place has been chosen as ‘the Fifth Ark’.”

He paused, his expression a bit odd. “The Vanished is the ‘Fifth Ark’.”

“…Aha. Those Enders say the Vanished is the ‘Promised Ark’, and now the ones who worship the Four Gods have slapped another name on us, calling us the ‘Fifth Ark’. The mighty and fearsome Vanished has suddenly become a good place to be…” Goathead shook his head, his tone clearly mocking. “Keep this up and they’ll probably start saying you’re a good person too. Is that their way of insulting you now…”

Duncan: “…”

After holding it in for a couple of seconds, he finally couldn't help himself. "I suggest you at least straighten out your worldview a little. You've recovered part of Saslokar's 'essence', after all. Acting like this makes it really hard for me to connect you with the 'Creator' of the second Long Night."

"It's not like I actually made it happen," Goathead muttered gloomily. "And the one who did isn't doing any better. The 'Holy Lord' is still stuck in the passage between the Abyssal Deep Sea, and Subspace. From how Dog describes it, it sounds like someone stuck in a toilet drain…"

Duncan felt he really couldn't keep talking with Goathead. Since when did this guy's jokes start carrying so many hidden jabs?

"Don't think I'm just being mean. I just feel something about this is strange," Goathead added quickly, noticing the look on the captain's face. "Those crazy Enders treating the Vanished as some kind of 'Promised Ark' is one thing. But now those Four Gods, whose own state is pretty suspicious, have suddenly sent 'divine will' and say the Vanished is the 'Fifth Ark' beyond the four Pilgrimage Arks… No matter how I hear it, it sounds wrong."

Goathead muttered as he turned his head on its base, then looked at Duncan very seriously.

"'Ark' has a special meaning on the Boundless Sea. The world only recognizes four true arks. Aside from the four Cathedral ships, any vessel that dares call itself an 'ark' is a heresy. And now the Vanished has suddenly been given the title of 'the Fifth Ark'. I can't shake the feeling that someone is trying to push the Vanished into danger… Of course, we've pretty much been dealing with one crisis after another this whole time anyway…"

Duncan's expression did not change as he listened to Goathead ramble on. When Goathead finally finished, Duncan casually asked, "When you say

‘they’, do you mean the four great Churches, or the Four Gods behind them?”

Goathead froze for a moment. “…Is there a difference? The four great Churches are just the executors of the Four Gods’ will. To put it plainly, they’re Their henchmen…”

“There is a difference,” Duncan said, shaking his head. “If you mean the four great Churches, they shouldn’t have the ability to push the Vanished into real danger yet. But if you mean the Four Gods behind the Churches, then I’m already very interested in Them. If this whole ‘Fifth Ark’ arrangement is something the Four Gods want to do, that’s perfect.”

Goathead: “…”

Instead, Duncan suddenly grew a little curious. He looked Goathead up and down. “You’re not interested? As the former ‘King of Dreams’, now that you’ve taken back part of Saslokar’s memories, you’re not even a little curious about your old ‘colleagues’?”

“Not interested at all,” Goathead said after thinking it over, shaking his head from side to side. “I haven’t recovered any memories from the time between the Great Annihilation and the Deep Sea era. So for me, the so-called ‘Elder Kings’ are just a completely foreign idea… Maybe that’s something to be regretted, but I don’t feel regret.”

Duncan gave Goathead a long, serious look, but in the end said nothing.

He walked over to the chart table and sat down on the chair there.

“I’ve already brought Nina and Morris back to the ship. As witnesses who saw the Great Annihilation with their own eyes, they will also attend this gathering.

“I have accepted the invitation from the Churches of the Four Gods. Right now this ship is heading to the agreed location near Lightwind Harbor. The

Radiant Star will meet us there. Lucretia will bring a group of her servants aboard to help us prepare for the gathering.

“Speed up. We’re going to keep our appointment.”

Chapter 675: The Gathering

The leaders and Bishops of the Churches of the Four Gods were going to gather on a ghost ship that had returned from Subspace to hold a meeting. No matter when you said that sentence, it would sound explosive. In any city state, if someone shouted such a thing in the street, everyone who heard it would have to think hard about whether to report it to the Inquisitors or to the nearest mental hospital.

But now it was really happening.

The Vanished arrived at the appointed place at the appointed time. It stopped in the calm waters near Lightwind Harbor, close to the great storm Cathedral. Then the Visitors from the four Pilgrimage Arks began to arrive one after another in small boats.

Shirley lay behind a railing at the stern deck, poking her head out as she watched the priests on the middle deck. They were all either nervously looking around or trying to act calm while their whole bodies stayed rigid. As she watched, she whispered to the Shadows beside her: “They really dared to come… Do you see that bald uncle over there? His forehead is so shiny, his whole head is covered in sweat…”

Dog’s muffled voice came from within the Shadows. “This is way too scary… Back in the city state, we would avoid even a few Guardians, let alone people at this level…”

“Times have changed… That’s the phrase, right?” Shirley said proudly. “Now they’re the ones who have to avoid us, at least on this ship. Hey, do

you want to jump out and scare them? You don’t get chances like this very often…”

“I can jump out, but the captain might beat you up afterward. Should I really jump?”

“No, no, no, I was just joking…”

On the deck, Lunie, the doll who had come to the Vanished with her Mistress, was calmly giving mental guidance to the Visitors, leading them across the central deck toward the door into the ship. The clockwork doll glanced back toward the stern deck, then turned to explain to a Deep Sea priest in Bishop’s robes beside her: “That is Miss Shirley. She is the Old Master’s student. You don’t need to be nervous.”

“But I can feel the presence of Abyssal demons…” the nervous Deep Sea Bishop couldn’t help saying. “It’s right next to that ‘Miss Shirley’…”

“That is Mr. Dog, Miss Shirley’s guardian dog,” Lunie explained calmly. “He is also the Old Master’s student. You don’t need to be nervous.”

The Deep Sea Bishop: “…?”

Lunie did not care about the strange look that suddenly appeared on his face. She clapped her hands and looked up to address the priests who had just boarded around her: “Let me stress some common points again

“The ropes on the ship may sometimes start moving on their own. If they tie you up, don’t worry. They’re just playing, and if you greet them they will loosen up. If you see buckets rolling around, don’t mind them either, they are probably just carrying things. If you pick up a silver haired doll’s head and don’t see the rest of the doll nearby, please bring the head to the main mast and give it to a talking pigeon. The pigeon will help return the head to its body.

“Also, do not go into areas that are not open to you. If you get lost, stop where you are right away. You are not forbidden to pray to a deity on this ship, but your deity cannot help you escape from a sealed cabin, so it is better to remember the rules I mentioned before. If you see something on the ship that looks like a Deep Sea spawn, stay calm and walk away. They are fish. Don’t mind any strange shadows that suddenly appear in mirrors or dark corners. That is Lady Agatha taking a walk, she will not enter the Visitors’ rooms…

“Always remember, the ship is safe and friendly in spirit. If you feel like you are about to die, please repeat this line in your heart, the ship is safe and friendly in spirit. Reflect on whether your own actions broke the rules, instead of doubting that the environment is at fault…

“Finally, I hope you all have a full and productive day aboard the great Vanished. Food will be served after the meeting. Please rest assured, it will all be substances that humans can eat.”

The clockwork doll smiled and bowed to the Visitors.

“Now, please follow me. We will head to the hall.”

The priests who had boarded were nervous, doubtful, or quietly on guard as they watched this ghost ship wrapped in countless strange tales and a dangerous aura. The “safety briefing” given by a clockwork doll on the deck did not ease the tension in the minds of these fairly normal people at all. It only made the eerie feeling of the place even stronger. But under the push of duty and responsibility, they could only swallow their misgivings and honestly follow the strange clockwork doll toward the ship’s interior.

Vanna stood at a distance under a mast, watching the busy Lunie with a trace of worry. She couldn’t help muttering quietly, “I don’t think Miss Lucretia should have sent Lunie to do the ‘reception’… It would have been better to send me and Mr. Morris…”

“But I think this is fine,” Helena’s voice sounded beside her. The dignified female Pope stood next to Vanna with a faint, puzzling smile on her face. Her gaze fell on the distant deck, and there was even a hint of cheer in her tone. “This will let them understand, in the shortest time, why I kept telling them before we boarded ‘not to make a fuss’ and to ‘treat everything on the Vanished as perfectly normal’.”

She paused, then looked thoughtfully at the huge silhouettes of the ark ships out on the sea. “The Bishops have deep learning and high skill in divine magic. But they have spent too long on arks where ‘order is normal’. That kind of ‘normal’ will not last forever.”

Vanna felt there was some deeper meaning in the Pope’s words. But before she could ask, Helena spoke first: “Are you getting used to this ship?”

“Uh… it’s fine,” Vanna said, startled, and quickly answered. “Everyone is very kind. I can also come into contact with a lot of knowledge I never knew before, and I keep gaining experience fighting heresy and blasphemy.”

“That’s good,” Helena said with a smile. Before Vanna could speak again, Helena was already walking toward the ship’s interior on her own. “We can talk after the gathering. We mustn’t make the ‘captain’ wait too long.”

Vanna froze for a moment. Right after that, she noticed that a pair of eyes seemed to be resting on her.

She followed that feeling and looked toward the source of the gaze, and saw a very tall figure, especially striking among the crowd, watching her from the distant deck.

It was a Senkin, dressed in a simple short robe, with skin like gray white rock and deep, steady eyes.

It was Frem, the leader of the Flamebearers.

The Senkin Pope, who was like a small giant, nodded to her from afar and then left in silence.

Vanna felt dazed. In the instant her eyes met that calm gaze, she could not help recalling that endless desert, and the old giant who had walked across the sands beside her…

A second later, Vanna suddenly snapped out of it. After a brief hesitation, she too stepped toward the ship's interior.

The captain's call was sounding in her heart. The time had come.

Everyone gathered in the largest cabin on the upper deck of the Vanished.

It was called a "meeting hall", but in truth it was just the dining room on the Vanished. The servants Lucretia had sent ahead had cleaned it up a bit, rearranging the tables and chairs to make it look like a conference room.

Compared to the splendid temples and grand shrines on the Pilgrimage Arks, this "meeting place" was clearly not very magnificent.

But the people gathered here obviously did not dare focus on how "plain" it was.

This was the Vanished, a shadow that had returned from Subspace, the "Fifth Ark" revealed and confirmed by the Four Gods together. Any unremarkable corner on this ship carried a different kind of meaning for the world.

Just being able to set foot on this ship was enough to become the memory of a lifetime, even for venerable Bishops and the "inner court" priests of the Pilgrimage Arks.

All unrelated personnel had already left. The automaton servants sent from the Radiant Star as "support" closed the doors of the hall as they went out.

The ordinary priests sat around the outer edge of the hall. Dozens of Bishops were divided into four areas according to the deities they followed. In the center of the hall, a ring of chairs had been set up. Helena, Frem, Banster, and Rune sat on four of those chairs. Facing them were the true Master of this ship and the Master's followers.

Duncan had deliberately asked Lucretia to arrange the venue this way.

He could tell that every gaze in the room was focused on him, and those looks were very complicated.

The nervous air around these people had never faded from the very start.

But he did not care.

"We meet again." His gaze first fell on Helena opposite him. This female Pope of the Deep Sea had been the first orthodox leader he met in this world, and one of his starting points for contact with the civilized world. "Welcome to my ship. I have kept my promise. I still stand on the side of 'civilization'."

Helena returned the greeting with proper, polite manners, but her eyes still could not help drifting toward Vanna, who sat not far from Duncan.

The Pope's expression stayed calm and gentle, but there was something odd deep in her eyes.

Just now, Vanna had very naturally sat down on the side that represented the Vanished…

This Saint of the Storm and Inquisitor of the Deep Sea had not hesitated at all.

But soon she put away that strange feeling. After quickly smoothing out her expression, she spoke, breaking the somewhat frozen mood in the room.

“This is a closed door meeting. I trust that everyone already understands its nature. So let us skip all formality and get straight to the point.

“We are here to discuss what has already happened to our world, and what is about to happen.”

She turned her head, her gaze landing on Rune beside her.

“The most learned among us has brought something. It may help explain to those here who still do not know the truth what… the ‘Great Annihilation’ is.”

Rune nodded, then gestured to the side.

A Scholar immediately stepped forward and handed him an object covered with black cloth.

Duncan watched curiously. He saw Rune lift the black cloth, and what lay under it surprised him for a moment.

It was a birdcage.

Inside, a small black bird sat quietly, looking very ordinary.

But Rune’s expression had become serious. He lifted the birdcage in his hands and showed it to everyone present.

“This is a black feathered short beaked auk. It has another famous name, well known in scholarly circles.

“Madbird. In 1726, the famous ‘Haipa Incident’ gave this little bird that terrifying name.

“To talk about the ‘Great Annihilation’, I must start with this little bird.”

Chapter 676: Haipa Incident

A bird?

Duncan had indeed thought about where he should start when he tried to explain the truth of the Great Annihilation and the current state of the Deep Sea era. After all, the collision of worlds and their “incompatibility” were such abstract ideas that not everyone could understand them in a short time. But he had never expected Rune to begin this topic with a small, ordinary-looking bird.

He looked up and saw that Morris, who sat beside him, had already grown thoughtful the moment he saw that “Madbird”.

Under the curious gazes of everyone present, Rune set the bird down on the table in front of him. His voice was calm and clear, like a patient mentor in a classroom, as he explained the ultimate truth of this world to the bishops who were gathered there:

“The black-feathered short-beaked auk is probably one of the oldest and most widespread bird species in this world. They lived along the safe coasts of the city-states, and also on lonely islands far out in the dangerous open sea. Explorers even found traces of them living in some dreadful waters that we classified as Visions. But if you only looked at their bodies and their habits, the black-feathered short-beaked auk had nothing special at all. It was only a very tough little bird. That was all.

“Until 1723, when some scholars suddenly put forward a very interesting, or rather very creative, idea: those animals that lived in this world together

with humans but had senses different from humans—what did ‘all things’ look like in their eyes?

“The first person who raised this idea was a famous scholar of the Truth Academy, Haipa Strumm. The thought came to him while he was playing with his pet dog at home. He gazed into the dog’s eyes and suddenly thought of how its eyes and brain were built differently from those of humans. He thought of how this special set of senses must understand and know the world in a strange way, different from humans. When that curiosity grew so strong he could no longer suppress it, he designed the famous ‘Haipa Experiment’.

“By using a series of complex occult studies rituals, he linked his own senses with those of an animal. The first test was carried out between him and his pet dog.

“The first experiment failed. The dog almost died in the process. Later examination showed that, in the instant the link formed, the dog suffered enormous mental pressure. It was completely beyond what an animal could endure.

“So Haipa Strumm designed a second test. This time, he decided to choose a slightly ‘lower’ life form, a creature with a simpler brain structure. He only needed to share this creature’s senses. He did not want it to die early from pressure because its brain was too complex. The creature he finally chose… was the black-feathered short-beaked auk.

“In the afternoon of a day in August 1726, Haipa Strumm finished all his preparations. He put the little bird in a special cage, where it could see the sky outside, and then he lay down on the experimental bed beside the cage. The ritual began.

“One hour later, Haipa Strumm was dead. His terrible screams and a strange roaring sound shattered every window in the laboratory. When his soul

collapsed at the moment of death, it triggered a howl in the Spirit Realm. As a result, twelve assistants and apprentices were harmed by that howl.

“Compared with many other experimental accidents and supernatural disasters that caused far more serious losses, the ‘Haipa Incident’ did not actually kill many people. However, some of the… chilling ‘facts’ that it revealed left a long shadow over the academic world. From that experiment onward, every attempt to build Shared Senses between different species was listed as an absolute taboo.

“And this is the ‘fact’ that was revealed in that accident.”

As Rune spoke, he reached into his robe and took out something. It seemed to be nothing more than a folded, ordinary piece of paper.

He unfolded the paper, and dense, crowded patterns came into Duncan’s view.

“People found a torn-off page of notes beside Haipa’s corpse. When they discovered his body, it was already terribly twisted. All his flesh had warped into a horrifying form, as if it had been corrupted by the power of the Elder Gods. This page of notes was clutched in the scholar’s right hand, the only part of his body that still kept a human shape. investigators judged that he probably drew these things in great haste, during his rapid fall into madness, using the last fragment of his sanity.

“Please do not worry. This is only a replica, copied from the original file. The parts that carried corruption have already been removed. It is safe for everyone to look at it.”

Rune lifted the paper and showed it to everyone in the hall.

What was on that page? What had Haipa Strumm actually seen before he died?

To be honest, even Duncan could not connect those abstract, tangled lines with the “Haipa Experiment” Rune had mentioned. He only saw a mass of curved lines that looked like spasms drawn on paper. Trembling shadows lay over a series of strange geometric shapes. Countless eye-like or hollow structures spread across the page. The first feeling it gave him… was nothing but eerie confusion.

The hall fell silent. The Haipa Incident was not a secret, but not everyone knew as much about it as the scholars did. Many bishops from the Deep Sea, from the Death Church, and from the Flamebearer Church were hearing these details for the first time. The strange and suspicious parts of this event made everyone sink into deep thought.

“This is what Haipa Strumm saw at the moment of his death through the Shared Senses,” Rune’s voice sounded in the quiet hall. “What you are looking at is the ‘world’ in the eyes of a black-feathered short-beaked auk. And that trembling cluster of lines piled near the edge… that is Haipa Strumm himself.”

A low buzzing of voices rose at once around the room. The bishops sitting along the edges of the hall began to whisper to one another. Some people looked at the still-ordinary-looking black seabird on the table with shock or deep thought in their eyes.

The “Madbird” seemed frightened. It hopped in the cage, beat its wings, and let out a series of sharp, clear cries.

Rune pulled the dark cloth back over the cage.

“This is what once happened in our world, and what still keeps happening in the ‘underlying essence’ of all things,” he said as he raised his head and calmly swept his gaze across the hall. “The essence of corruption lies in the ‘incompatibility’ of all things. What is only a simple thing in our view,

under another view—or under another set of ‘rules’—is deadly corruption piled upon corruption.”

In the time that followed, Rune slowly described everything he had seen in the deepest part of the Nameless One’s dream.

He spoke of the true nature of the Great Annihilation, the truth behind the collision of worlds, the reasons behind the many corruptions and twisted phenomena of the Deep Sea era today, and those “eternal conflicts” that still remained in the laws at the bottom of the world.

“…On the day the Great Annihilation took place, many worlds ‘collided’ with each other,” Rune said. “We still do not know why this collision happened. But the result… was a ‘Haipa Incident’ spread across countless civilizations, countless races, countless worlds. In that collision, every world was both a ‘Madbird’ to all the others and a ‘Haipa Strumm’ to all the others. Under the view of the ‘basic rules of the worlds’, unspeakable corruption twisted everything. All the old order vanished. And the survivors…”

Rune stopped. He slowly stood up and looked around at every person there.

“We, and everything around us, even the entire Deep Sea era,” he said, “are nothing more than Haipa Strumm’s last scream at the moment of his death. That scream is still echoing to this day, but it is already close to its end.”

The old man let out a soft breath and slowly sat back down in his seat.

“I am finished,” he said. “Does anyone wish to add anything?”

As he spoke, his gaze fell on Duncan, who sat opposite him.

“You spoke very fully,” Duncan said. “This is all we currently know about the Great Annihilation. Next, we should talk about the gods—the guesses about their true nature, and what you have been doing recently. That is what I care about most.”

The bishops around them stirred again. The four popes sitting on the other side of the table exchanged a brief look when Duncan finished speaking. The noise quickly faded, and the Flamebearer Pope—the tall figure in simple robes, with skin gray-white like stone—gave a small nod.

“From the clues we have, the gods should be the powerful or special beings that remained after each world was destroyed in the Great Annihilation,” Frem said in his low voice. “They are like ‘charred cores’ left after a great burning, carrying the last glow of a world.”

As he spoke, Frem raised his hand and traced the outline of the Flamebearer emblem over his chest, as if confessing his offense in ‘judging the gods’. But he went on:

“…The Great Annihilation destroyed everything of the Old World. Strictly speaking, the gods also did not survive that disaster. And as for this… we actually noticed it a very long time ago.”

When he heard Frem’s words, Duncan’s eyes widened a little: “You had noticed this before?”

At the same time, he saw shock flash across the faces of Morris and Vanna beside him. Clearly, even as Saints, this was the first time they had heard such words from the mouth of a pope.

This was a “secret” kept only inside the Pilgrimage Arks.

Frem gave a small nod.

“Yes,” he said. “We noticed it long ago. It is only now that we understand the reason behind it all.

“The gods are dead and have already begun to enter their ‘decay phase’… but only a few high-ranking church members who patrol the border on the Pilgrimage Arks know this truth. And there is another truth…”

Frem paused for a moment. He raised his head and gazed into Duncan’s eyes.

“The Pilgrimage Arks were created to slow the gods’ rot,” he said. “And now, this ‘slowing’ is almost at its limit.

“The filth born from the gods’ decay… is about to seep into the mortal world.”

Chapter 677: Pilgrimage

Ever since the day he first saw those “giant ships” that were like small city-states, ever since he learned that these huge monsters kept “pilgrimaging” across the sea, Duncan had always had questions about these astounding creations—the Pilgrimage Arks.

What exactly did the Pilgrimage Arks mean? Were their special “pilgrimage” journeys really just patrols?

People in the city-states often said that the Pilgrimage Arks represented the great power of the Four Gods. They were the highest symbols of the Church’s might and also the “palaces” of the four True Gods in the mortal world. The Church sent the Arks to patrol the Boundless Sea to intimidate heretics and to protect the city-states from being corrupted by certain malicious beings in Subspace. At first, Duncan had had no doubts about this explanation.

But as he came into contact with the Four Gods’ churches more and more—especially after he learned many inside stories about the Church from Vanna, Morris, and Agatha—he began to see problems.

The ones who truly fought heretics and malevolent spirits were the inquisitors and guardians of each city-state. The ones who truly intercepted cultists at sea and rescued sailors were the regular fleets of the Four Gods’ churches. The ones who truly watched for Subspace corruption and strengthened the city-states’ defenses were the bells of the Cathedrals, the bishops’ prayers, and the strictly laid-out systems of Cathedrals and bell towers.

The four solemn Pilgrimage Arks… in fact, never took part in any matter that concerned the mortal world.

For three quarters of every year, they patrolled certain hidden routes. Those routes were invisible and unmeasurable to the mortal world, as if they lay in the cracks between dimensions of the Mortal Realm, and they stayed far from every city. For the rest of the time, they took turns patrolling near the eternal Veil at the border, where they traded only the bare minimum of information with the Church's border fleets. They did not deal with any city-state at all. They even deliberately avoided the patrol ships of the border city-states.

Only in very rare cases did these Arks dock at a city-state. For example, after some great event like the Black Sun incident in Pland, they would appear before the eyes of the world.

Aside from times like that, the Arks had no contact with the mortal world. Even within the four great Churches, they were always wrapped in a mist of mystery. Most priests would never in their whole lives have a chance to set foot on a Pilgrimage Ark. Only those chosen as "Saints" could be brought aboard while they were still apprentices, and even then, they were allowed to move only in certain areas. After they finished the learning and training they needed, they were sent back to their original cities. From beginning to end, these Saints never had the chance to touch the true secrets of the Arks.

All these clues showed that the very existence of the "Pilgrimage Arks" was filled with huge doubts. Their real purpose had always been hidden.

Now, Duncan finally had his answer.

"…The four Pilgrimage Arks we have now were built only a few decades ago," Frem said in his low voice. "Before these 'giant ships' were put into use, the four Churches also had an earlier generation of 'arks'. But those

ships could not be compared at all with the Cathedral-ships we have today…”

Frem’s voice flowed like stone slowly grinding. It carried a calm weight that made people relax and trust him without noticing.

“The earlier Church ‘arks’ were only big ships,” he said. “Back then, they were still just part of the Holy See’s ocean fleet, a link in its armed forces. They were not as mysterious as they are today, and they were not cut off from the world like they are today.

“The Cathedral-ships we have now are things on a completely different level. Rather than saying they are four ‘great ships’… it is more accurate to say that they are four ‘anchors’. They hold the gods’ sanity in place at some ‘point of balance’ outside the mortal world.”

Duncan did not speak. He only watched the pope opposite him with a serious expression. He knew that Frem was explaining this mainly for his sake. All the other popes and bishops here came from the Pilgrimage Arks. These people were clearly those who already knew the truth.

“…It is impossible now to say exactly who first sensed the truth,” Frem went on. “It was a chain of revelations and inspirations. In benedictions, we heard a whispered Truth. In visions from sacred incense, we saw darkness and corruption piling up. The souls of the four of us felt more than once a ‘pull’ from beyond the world. The gods drew our minds to a vast, chaotic place and let us see Their death and Their shadows… and during all this, the link between the priests of the mortal world and the Four Gods kept breaking again and again. That was around the year 1822.”

At this point, Frem paused for a moment. Lucretia, who sat not far to Duncan’s right, suddenly seemed to think of something and said: “1822… the ‘Cold Harbor Silence’?”

“Yes. The Cold Harbor Silence,” a hoarse voice replied. “That event is well known, but it is only one fragment, one piece left behind because it could not be fully covered up, among a long chain of worsening incidents.”

The answer did not come from Frem, but from Banster, who sat beside him. The Death Pope wore a black robe. His voice was rough, and his old, pale face looked almost like that of a dead man.

“In that incident, every priest in the city-state suddenly lost contact with Bartok, the God of Death,” Banster said. “For twenty-four hours of ‘Silence’, they heard in their minds a continuous, terrifying, hollow wailing and screaming that only they could hear. Afterwards, foul blood flowed out of the ‘Sanctum’. The city’s archbishop sacrificed himself and dissolved in that foul blood to protect the Grand Cathedral. When it was all counted up, seventeen priests had died as martyrs during the ‘Silence’, and seventy-seven more fell into permanent madness after seeing things outside the real world. Their minds shattered.

“And in my judgement, for twenty years after that, the ‘Silence’ kept leaving lasting effects. The brief disappearance of the divine protective wards weakened the Mortal Realm’s defenses over the Frost Sea region. The influences of Subspace, the Abyssal Deep, and the Spirit Realm all slipped in while the defenses were low. With Cold Harbor as the center, the city-states around the Frost Sea produced, in that period, more ‘innate psionics’ than all the other city-states in the world put together.”

Banster fell silent and looked toward Rune.

“Yes, just as Banster said, the Cold Harbor Silence of 1822 was only one fragment,” Rune said with a nod. “The real situation was that, for quite a long time, across the entire Boundless Sea, the connection with the gods was growing harder and even dangerous. Everyday prayers often received no answer, and worse still, they sometimes received answers that never

should have come. The protection over the city-states grew weaker. Strange incidents at sea became more and more common. In one revelation and vision after another, we finally confirmed the gods' terrible 'state'."

The hall grew quiet again.

Duncan knew the gods were dead. His followers knew it as well. The four popes and the bishops of the Pilgrimage Arks all knew it too. But when this matter was laid plainly on the table—when every piece of information and every past incident was placed side by side and tied to the Great Annihilation—a strange, heavy pressure still spread through the room.

"…So you built these huge Pilgrimage Arks to strengthen the link with the gods and to slow Their decay," Duncan said at last, breaking the silence. "I am not interested in the exact 'principles' of the process. I only want to know how effective it really was. Did it work? Just now Frem said the Arks' delaying effect has already reached its limit. What exactly does that mean?"

"It did work, at least at the beginning," Helena said with a nod. "The Arks are anchors for the gods. The 'death' of the gods is a long and complex process. Strictly speaking, that process cannot be stopped at all. It is like the turning of the laws of the world—it cannot be reversed. But the presence of the 'anchors' can at least keep the gods in a relatively stable state until They completely 'disappear'. According to our earliest estimates… it should have worked for several centuries, perhaps even a thousand years.

"Our first thought was that if we had such a long 'buffer period', we might have a chance to find other methods to slow the gods' decay even further. We might even find… find…"

Helena suddenly stopped. Some words were hard for her to say out loud. It seemed that even though she and the other popes had already taken action toward that goal, she still did not wish to admit certain "facts".

Rune, Banster, and Frem also fell silent, their expressions complicated.

Beside Duncan, Lucretia frowned in puzzlement. Nina and Shirley could not hide the curiosity on their faces. Morris opened his mouth as if he wanted to speak, but he held back.

Soft, unreal waves sounded in Duncan's ears. Faint whispers seemed to murmur to him from behind the thick Veil. He felt dazed for a moment and looked down at the tabletop in front of him.

A faint trace of water appeared on the table, then quickly faded away.

He looked at that trace of water, then raised his head and looked at Helena across from him.

"Find a replacement, right?"

Helena's eyes widened as she stared at Duncan in shock.

Duncan only shook his head and did not explain. After a few seconds of silence, he spoke again in a low, thoughtful voice: "…But only a few decades have passed. That is still far away from the 'centuries' you expected."

"Yes. Things have grown worse than we imagined," Banster said, his voice hoarse and heavy. "We once thought the gods' current 'balance' might last a thousand years. But the power of decay and rot has already begun to invade the whole world. The Arks' 'pilgrimage' journeys were first meant to strengthen the link between the gods and the mortal world. But now, we spend half our time trying to 'filter' the corruption that spills out as They decay…

"This makes us… deeply sorrowful."

Banster ended his words with a sigh.

After a moment of thought, Duncan broke the silence again: “So you have taken new action—the fleets gathering in the border seas, right?”

Chapter 678: The Road in the Mist

The four great Churches had gathered massive fleets along the borders of the civilized world, and they had been doing this for quite some time.

Because regular patrol fleets had been reduced, and a huge number of ships, personnel, and supplies were being redeployed toward the region near the Eternal Veil, such a large?scale mobilization could not be hidden from the border city?states. Long before today, Lucretia had already learned of these unusual moves from Sara Mell, yet until now, she and Duncan had never been able to figure out the Churches' purpose—until now.

The truth that the gods were dead, the true function of the Pilgrimage Ark, and the fact that the gods had already entered the "corruption stage" ahead of time finally let Duncan guess the purpose of those fleets.

After a moment of silence, Helena finally spoke: "We are looking for Them. That was one of our goals, and it was our very first goal."

Lucretia sprang to her feet, staring at the four popes across from her in disbelief: "You mean the gods are inside that thick fog of the Eternal Veil?! Right outside the border?!"

Banster, the old man in black robes, answered her, slowly shaking his head: "We are not sure. But we are certain that the first traces of rot seeped in from the Eternal Veil at the border. So for now, our plan is only to find the source of that presence. As for what we will see at that source… no one knows."

Rune picked up the thread: “It might be the gods’ divine realm. It might just be some kind of junction that links Them to the mortal world. Or it might be…”

He stopped there and did not finish the rest.

After a brief silence, Duncan suddenly asked: “You said this was only one of your goals. What about the others? Besides searching for Them, what else do you intend to do?”

Helena answered: “Another goal is to figure out what has really happened to this world. Reports of the border collapsing are increasing by the day. Together with the recent ‘malfunctions’ of the Sun, all kinds of anomalies related to the Eternal Veil are becoming more and more frequent. It is obvious that the thick fog there may be hiding secrets closely tied to our world’s present state and its very foundations.”

Duncan could not help pressing her: “So you figure out what has happened to the world… and then what?” He had an instinctive feeling that Helena was not finished.

Helena said: “If possible, we will try to find a ‘new route’ that can pass all the way through the Veil, then take as many people as we can out before the worst happens. If the ‘collapse’ inside the Veil is already set in stone, then our only way out is to leave. There may be other worlds beyond the Veil—wider worlds.”

“Maybe those worlds will not be very habitable, maybe the world beyond the Veil will be even more dangerous than the Boundless Sea. But as long as we can still survive, no matter how harsh the environment, it can become a new cradle for civilization. As long as we stay alive, life will find a way out, even if that means a long and painful process of adaptation… or even mutation.”

As Helena’s voice fell, the hall fell silent. Duncan could feel Vanna, Morris, and the others beside him unconsciously holding their breath. After several seconds, he finally heard Vanna break the silence: “Has the situation already become that bad?”

Rune shook his head: “The worst part is that we do not even know how bad things can get. Without the warning from the Vanished, we would not even know that last time the Sun went completely dark for twelve hours. During those twelve hours, the four arks vanished from this world together with the other city?states. That only made us even more certain that we must face whatever is coming with the worst possible expectations.”

Duncan suddenly spoke in a flat voice. His tone was not loud, but his words fell coldly into everyone’s heart: “But ‘the world beyond the Veil’ is only a guess, a guess with no basis. Very likely, this is nothing more than your wishful effort.”

Helena’s expression did not change at all. She calmly and openly met Duncan’s gaze: “It is better than doing nothing. We are not acting because we are sure something will succeed, but because we have no other choice. There may be nothing beyond the Eternal Veil. It is even very possible that the Eternal Veil has no end at all, and we will never find that so?called new route. But we still have to do something…”

She stopped. Frem, who had barely spoken until now, broke the silence in a low voice: “Under an even worse scenario, we are even considering how to survive inside the Eternal Veil itself.”

Nina could not help crying out in shock: “Survive inside the Eternal Veil?!” She had kept quiet all this time, just sitting quietly beside her Uncle Duncan, because she felt this was not the kind of occasion where she could speak up as she pleased. But this time she really could not hold back: “Can

anyone even live there? Can humans really survive and multiply in that fog?”

“Not right now,” Frem said calmly, shaking his head. “At least with the current form of mortal life, and with what we currently understand about the rules of the Eternal Veil, human society still cannot survive and multiply in that fog. And by ‘human society’ here, I also mean elves and Senkin.”

Nina opened her mouth: “Then…”

Helena spoke softly: “That is what I mentioned just now. We may need a long and painful process of adaptation, or even mutation. We may need to become something that is no longer ‘us’ in order to survive in the world that comes after. Perhaps we will become like those eerie shadows that appear in the mist, or like those murmuring noises in the wind…”

Duncan asked again: “And if that still is not enough? The chaos of the Eternal Veil may be something that can never be ‘adapted’ to. If both the new route plan and the adaptation plan fail…”

Banster spoke calmly: “Then we will go to the Spirit Realm. If the Spirit Realm still does not work, then we will launch a full assault on the Abyssal Deep Sea. Since there are people in this world who can summon demons into the Mortal Realm, we can also go to the worlds of those demons. If they can survive in the Abyssal Deep, in the Deep Sea, then so can we. And if even that does not work, then we still have Subspace.”

This time even Shirley could not hold back: “S?Subspace?”

Banster nodded slightly: “No one can survive Subspace. Every mortal who has seen it dissolves into eternal madness and distortion. But if we really reach the final moment, Subspace can still be a choice. Any choice, even the worst choice, is better than calmly and meekly walking toward Doomsday.”

Shirley and Nina both fell silent, a stunned look on their faces.

Duncan wore a thoughtful expression. He fixed his gaze on the four figures across the table for a long time before finally speaking softly: “Is this the ‘revelation’ you received?”

Helena spoke slowly: “This is not a revelation. These are ‘instructions’ we received through one chaotic, faint exchange after another.” She raised her hand and traced on her chest the sigil of storm and the Deep Sea. “They told us to stay alive—to live on at any cost, by any means.”

Duncan did not speak for a moment.

He fell into thought, and was somewhat shaken.

He had to admit that these people, who always seemed late to every ‘incident’ and even a bit slow and powerless, had actually done far more than he had imagined.

Compared to the Elder Gods and the Vanished, they truly did not have much power. But they were trying to do things that even the Vanished and the Elder Gods could not do.

After that silence had dragged on for an unknown time, he finally broke it: “I want to know what progress you have made so far.”

Helena hesitated for a few seconds, then sighed softly: “Unfortunately, our progress is still limited. We have set up several forward bases at the critical line six nautical miles inside the Eternal Veil and can barely hold our ground there, but that is all. To this day, no one has been able to break the ‘record’ left by the Vanished back then.”

Duncan shook his head, his tone quite calm: “the Vanished got into ‘trouble’ as soon as it returned from beyond six nautical miles inside the Veil. Strictly speaking, that was not really a successful ‘exploration record’.”

The four popes' expressions all turned a bit strange. Clearly, none of them felt it was suitable to continue that topic.

Duncan did not mind. He merely adjusted his posture, quickly sorted out his thoughts, and then changed the subject: "Since your progress on that front has already stalled, I happen to have some 'intel' that might be useful. You will probably be interested."

Helena spoke without thinking: "Intel?"

Duncan nodded and said unhurriedly: "A couple of days ago, my daughter and I 'captured' a ship. It was a large vessel built by the Annihilators, the 'base' they used in the previous Lightwind Harbor incident to invade the dreamscape. It was covered in traces of bloody rituals and profane constructs… but that is not the main point.

"The point is that a ship like that clearly cannot dock and resupply at any normal city?state. So guess where its home port is."

Helena, Rune, and the others looked at each other, but they almost immediately reacted. Rune was the first to speak: "Wait, you mean… the border?!"

"Yes. They are hiding inside that fog." Duncan did not keep them in suspense and instead nodded with a serious expression. "It is one of the Annihilators' nests, and it may even be their largest nest and 'headquarters'. They call it the 'Holy Land'. Right now I still cannot be sure what shape this so?called Holy Land is in, and I do not know whether it lies on the 'near side' or the 'far side' of the six?nautical?mile line. But even if it is on the relatively stable near side, a 'Veil colony' that has been hidden inside the Eternal Veil for so long, and can even operate steadily as a large resupply port, should be of great research value to us."

Chapter 679: The Signal Appears Again

A nest hidden in the dense fog at the border, a place that might have been operating steadily for many years—invisible to the entire civilized world and even in the blind spot of the Four Gods Church's surveillance. In that place, the Annihilators had built a "Veil colony" capable of surviving long?term inside the "Eternal Veil". This news shocked everyone present at once.

Banster's voice was hoarse and gloomy, and the expression on the old man in black robes was especially grave: "For so many years, we have been searching for the cultists' nests. Among the three main heretical cults, the Enders are 'freaks' that are discontinuous on the timeline, and the Suntists are sheltered by the Black Sun outside the Mortal Realm. Only the Annihilators… in theory they must have one or more nests somewhere in the Mortal Realm, but after all these years, we have never found them…"

Helena nodded: "I never thought it would be hiding in a place like that. But it does explain how they managed to evade the Church's hunts for so many years. If those Annihilators have really found a way to survive long?term in the Eternal Veil, then they have clearly taken a big step ahead of us."

As she spoke, she turned her gaze toward Rune: "How do you think those cultists have managed to survive at the border?"

Rune shook his head: "'Holy Land' might not be something they built by their own power. Technology does not develop overnight. No matter how much forbidden knowledge the Annihilators have, they cannot create a

sanctuary world that far beyond our imagination out of nothing. After all, we have all dealt with them. Everyone knows exactly how capable that twisted bunch really is. I suspect much more that they found some kind of naturally existing ‘legacy’ in the fog… after all, that is the border. Anything can appear there.”

He suddenly stopped there, lifted his head, and looked at Duncan with a very serious expression: “From what you just said, it sounds like you still have not located this ‘nest’ exactly. Then how can you be sure that it…”

“I told you, I captured one of their ships.” Duncan answered casually. “Right now that ship is sailing back toward the ‘Holy Land’ under my orders. It will probably take a few more days. Judging by its current course, its destination should be some hidden spot on the southeastern border, not very far from here… The Vanished will set out before long and meet it before it enters the Veil. What about you? Interested in joining the fun?”

The popes looked at one another when they heard this.

From Duncan’s first couple of sentences, they had already sensed the eerie, dangerous side of this ghost captain. But fortunately, this dangerous power was now standing on their side.

So all that was left for them to consider was how to respond to this “invitation”.

After a short pause for thought, Frem suddenly spoke: “The southeastern border… the Death Church happens to have a fleet over there.” He glanced at Helena. “‘Tide’ should also be in that area, right? They should all be able to make it in time.”

“Yes. The Deep Sea Church can send the nearest fleet over.” Helena nodded at once, looking at Duncan. “Wiping out the cultists’ nest is our duty. And we also know how to deal with the ‘corruption’ they leave behind.”

Several gazes fell on Banster. The old man in black robes did not show much change in expression. He only tightened his face and nodded: “I will send Rest and No Rest. They are powerful new warships.”

The popes and bishops all nodded when they heard this, as if to show their approval of Banster’s arrangement. But Duncan could not help focusing on the Death Church’s very distinctive way of naming its ships. After holding it in for a long time, he still could not stop himself from saying: “They sound like sister ships… the names are quite something…”

“Many of the Death Church’s powerful warships serve in twin squadrons. That is related to our faith.” Banster explained with a very straight face. “We believe everything in this world has two sides, just like the opposition and companionship between life and death.”

Duncan felt that the old gentleman in black robes did not seem to notice his strong urge to make fun of them—but he also felt that this topic should end here.

Because he was afraid the next thing they would come up with would be something like a warship named “Nine Clans Wipeout” or something along those lines…

“Then we will settle it like this.” He nodded and somewhat stiffly pulled the topic back on track. “I will have the Vanished lead your fleets to the rendezvous point. But I have to warn you ahead of time: some time has already passed since I ‘captured’ that ship. The cultists left in the Holy Land have certainly realized what happened. They will already be prepared—either they have withdrawn, or they have set up an ambush in the surrounding waters, or the Holy Land itself may have formidable combat capabilities. You must take these risks and variables into account in advance.”

“Risk and uncertainty have always been an indispensable part of cleansing evil filth.” Banster’s face was calm. “Our warriors are long used to it.”

“Good. Then next I will tell you about the intel I have gathered from those Annihilators lately…”

…

sunlight streamed through the window, falling softly into the room. The air was filled with the strong smell of medicinal plasters, mixed with a hint of refreshing incense.

Ted Riel stood before the window, gazing outside in thought.

From this vantage point, he could see the massive Academy Ark moored along the city’s shoreline, and in the other direction, the steep “shore” along the edge of the Flamebearer temple.

On the streets, he could still see citizens hurrying toward the docks, watching groups of people running together to see those majestic Cathedral ships. The festive banners strung between the buildings that morning were still fluttering in the sunlight, and colored paper flowers blown from somewhere spiraled past the window on the wind before vanishing into the clear sky in the distance.

People did not know the details of this special “gathering”. They did not know what the gods’ heralds were discussing together. They certainly did not know what changes the Fifth Ark had brought, nor that the popes, Their Eminences, had already left the ark and gone to that ghost ship the world had feared and watched warily for a century. For most ordinary people, all of this was far too distant from their lives.

“…Ignorance really is a kind of blessing sometimes.”

Ted Riel pulled his gaze back from the street and murmured to himself.

A voice came almost at once from the bed not far away: “But if your own student has that ‘blessing’, it is not such a blessing for the teacher.”

Ted Riel’s mouth twitched. He turned his head to look at Taran Ael, the scholar lying on the bed: “A slipped disc still doesn’t stop you from making snide remarks, does it?”

“Exactly. It’s my disc that’s slipped, not my vocal cords…”

“…Next time you are destined to get hemorrhoids, and when that happens, I’m going to eat three Bay Inferno Wraps in front of you in fifteen minutes!”

“Rahm preserve me. As a dignified Truth Keeper, can’t you be a little more refined and generous?” Taran Ael wriggled on the bed to change position, then bared his teeth and flopped back where he was. “Look at the state I’m in…”

Ted Riel did not answer this grand scholar, who was stuck in bed with a bad back and so bored that he could only tease people for fun. After a moment of silence, he glanced out the window again: “I wonder what they’re going to talk about today.”

Taran Ael lifted his head to look at the friend who had come to visit him: “You are a Truth Keeper. You really don’t know anything?”

“Taran, you know the Pilgrimage Arks operate independently from the city? state system.” Ted Riel shook his head. “There are some things that become corruption for the whole world the moment they spread outside the arks. When a Truth Keeper walks too closely among ordinary people, they naturally have to keep a certain distance from the deepest secrets.”

“…That’s true.” Taran Ael thought for a moment and sighed: “So you, the ‘big shot’, can only come keep me, the patient, company when the big bosses are busy talking things over…”

Ted Riel did not respond, and his silence only made a certain grand scholar feel even more bored. Taran Ael stayed quiet for barely half a minute before suddenly blurting out: “Seriously, do you think Their Eminences the popes are going to end up fighting with the ‘captain’ on that ship…?”

“What do you think? How about I pass all these questions on to Rune when Teacher Rune comes back and let him answer you personally?”

Taran Ael shrugged and finally fell silent.

Just then, hurried footsteps suddenly sounded in the hallway, cutting off the “warm, lively conversation” between the scholar and the Truth Keeper.

There was a knock at the door, along with a slightly nervous, hurried young voice: “Teacher, something’s happened…”

Taran Ael recognized his student’s voice and spoke at once before Ted could say anything: “Come in.”

The door opened, and a clumsy young apprentice came in, arms full of paper tape.

But just as he was about to speak, he saw the Truth Keeper standing in the room. He immediately froze where he was, suddenly forgetting what he wanted to say.

Ted Riel was the first to break the silence: “Your teacher is currently locked in combat with his lumbar disc. So if it’s just a problem with your studies, ask me.”

Taran Ael braced himself and forced his way up into a sitting position, baring his teeth in pain as he looked at the nervous young apprentice standing in the middle of the room: “Joshua, calm down—what happened?”

“Oh… oh!” The young apprentice finally reacted. He quickly bent to salute the Truth Keeper, then hurried over to his teacher’s bedside. “Teacher,

there’s a situation at the offshore research station. They received a signal, coming from the center of that ‘glowing orb’ emitter…”

As he spoke, he handed the long strip of paper covered in waveform graphs to Taran Ael.

“This signal… is very similar to the one the glowing orb sent during the Sun’s blackout…”

Chapter 680: After the Meeting

After hearing Apprentice Joshua's report, Taran Ael and Ted Riel almost turned to look at each other at the same time. Before Ted could speak, Taran had already turned his head and said to his apprentice: "The metal cabinet by the window in the next room, second door from the left, blue paper-tape box—run!"

"Ah… okay!!" Joshua answered in a panic, then spun around and dashed out of the room.

A moment later came a whole series of crashes in the corridor, as if he had run into something, followed by the sound of frantic rummaging in the next room. Before Ted Riel started to worry that this reckless young man meant to tear the whole building apart, Joshua rushed back in, all wind and fire, holding a sealed archive box in his arms.

Ted Riel took the records from the archive box and compared them with the paper tape Joshua had just brought. Then he walked to the side of Taran Ael's sickbed and held both strips out for the Grand Scholar to see.

Taran Ael's gaze fell on the old and new strips of paper. He studied every peak and valley in the lines there, and his expression grew darker and heavier.

"Is it the same signal?" The voice of the Truth's Truth Keeper came from beside him.

"Setting aside the distortion from interference and any error from the device itself… it should be the same signal," Taran Ael said, his face grave.

“…This is the ‘Light-Signal’ Lady Lucretia recorded aboard the Radiant Star,” Ted Riel stared at the earlier strip that had been sealed in the paper-tape box, his expression thoughtful. “It was the information cyclically released from inside the glowing orb while the Sun was extinguished. But we still have not deciphered its meaning…”

He suddenly lifted his head and looked out the window at the sky.

The Sun was slowly drawing near the distant rooftops. The glorious twin rune rings shone brightly in the sky, and the magnificent corona still poured out endless light and heat. Time was nearing dusk, but Vision 001 itself showed no sign of going out.

Yet the “glowing geometric body” near Lightwind Harbor had suddenly begun to release this strange “signal” again, the same signal that had appeared while the Sun was extinguished… Why?

“Has this signal been repeating the whole time?” Taran Ael asked his Student.

“Y-yes,” Joshua nodded in a hurry, clearly very nervous. “When the observatory sent us the data, the signal had already repeated three times…”

“What do you make of this?” Taran Ael turned his head and looked at his old friend.

“…I have to go to the observatory myself. These signals feel very unusual. I keep thinking that strange ‘glowing geometric body’ is trying to… ‘make contact’ with the outside world. Maybe I can find some clues if I go there in person,” Ted Riel said quickly as he walked to the coat rack, picked up his coat and hat, and put them on. “I also need to tell the people meeting on the Fifth Ark. They may not have noticed anything abnormal yet…”

The Truth’s Truth Keeper finished getting ready to go out, then picked up his heavy book that recorded many arts of sacred miracles. He opened it to

the page that showed a “door”. But he suddenly stopped, lifted his eyelids, and looked at the Grand Scholar lying on the bed.

Taran Ael suddenly felt a flicker of unease. “…Why are you looking at me like that?”

“If something happens to the Sun again this time, you are going to lie in this bed honestly—you already shook up the academy’s whole safety review with your last amazing stunt.”

“Nonsense! My lumbar disc is almost poking into my hip; where could I even go?!” Taran Ael glared at once. If not for his ruined back, he looked as if he would leap up and bite someone. “You think I want to be scrambling along the roofs and bell towers of the teaching building?”

But Ted Riel only shook his head at that: “…Experience tells me that a herniated disc cannot fully stop your curiosity. As long as the target has enough research value, you are perfectly able to crawl out of a sickbed.”

As he spoke, the Truth’s Truth Keeper strolled unhurriedly to the Grand Scholar’s bedside and tapped his heavy Book of sacred miracles with his knuckles. A small, ghostly scalpel appeared in his hand.

Taran Ael instantly understood the source of his earlier unease. He shouted at once: “What are you doing… I’m warning you, Ted… don’t you dare… damn it, you can’t!”

Ted Riel paid no attention at all to the Grand Scholar’s protests. He pointed the scalpel at Taran Ael from a distance and tapped three times in the air: “This will effectively keep you confined to this bed. Don’t worry—when I come back, I’ll cure you.”

“Ted, you damn XX! The God of Wisdom did not grant you knowledge of disease and healing for this! I… (Elven curses) (Lightwind Harbor curses) (vulgarities not fit to hear)!!”

The room filled with the Grand Scholar’s agitated shouts, though his voice no longer had the strength it once did. The Truth’s Truth Keeper, however, had already turned away and stepped through a door that appeared from thin air.

Only Apprentice Joshua remained in the room, at a complete loss as he faced his Teacher.

“…What are you staring at? Go bring me my hemorrhoid ointment!”

“Oh… oh!”

…

The main part of the meeting had already ended. After they exchanged enough information and reached a series of open “cooperation agreements”, Duncan and the gathered Church leaders announced a recess together.

But unlike a normal “meeting”, there were no flashing cameras here, no crowd of reporters to record this precious moment, no photographs or footage to preserve any detail of the proceedings—there was not even a single page of written agreement left on paper.

The things they discussed here were simply too sensitive. Any form of record might, on some future day, undergo some kind of unpredictable “change”.

But none of the attendees minded. They believed that the Four Gods as witness were enough.

The Bishops left the hall first. Lucretia’s Servants led those Guests to a temporary rest area on the deck, where tea and snacks had already been prepared in advance. In half an hour, there would even be a small barbecue on deck.

Many of the attendees still felt a sense of unreality. After all… to enjoy a rich dinner on the deck of the Vanished, with the sea wind blowing… even the most imaginative poet or playwright in the world would hardly dare to conceive of such a scene with a clear head.

Other attendees had a different worry. They still fretted about the “food safety” on this ship. Even though they had accepted that “Captain Duncan has a human nature and has already formed a cooperative relationship with the Church”, they still felt that something harmful to the body and mind of an ordinary person might appear aboard this ship—especially at a so-called “barbecue party”.

…To be honest, their worries were not wrong.

But it did not matter.

Because it was not yet time to return to the Pilgrimage Ark—the four Popes still remained in the hall, and the “closed-door meeting” after the open session was the truly important part.

“Now it’s just us,” Duncan looked at the four people sitting opposite him in the hall, which suddenly felt quiet and empty after the Bishops left. “So we can talk about some matters that are not so suitable to put on the table.”

“Where would you like to start?” Helena asked. “We will do all we can to answer your questions.”

“…It is not really a question,” Duncan thought for a moment, then spoke slowly. “I just want to know—do you intend to hide your operations in the border seas from the city-states forever? I do not mean the search for the Gods, but the search for new routes. If you really find a new route, how do you plan to persuade city-states, who knew nothing about these plans beforehand, to carry out a population migration on that scale? And the rest of those ambitious ‘migration’ plans…”

He paused there, and his expression grew more serious. “To be honest, they do sound exciting. But once you calm down and think, you can see there are too many hasty decisions, too many things taken for granted—especially when you mean to complete these ‘great feats’ while hiding them from the entire world. How high do you think your real chance of success is?”

“…The secrecy is also a last resort. There is too much information that cannot be given to ordinary people. The ‘secrets’ of the border, if they spread into normal city-states, could easily cause a catastrophe,” Helena sighed. “Of course, your criticism is right. There are too many hasty and wishful parts in these plans, and no matter what, such large-scale actions can never be hidden forever… All I can say is that we never expected the situation to worsen this quickly.”

“We first made our plans on the scale of several centuries,” Frem nodded beside her. “With enough time as a buffer, we could have relied on the efforts of several generations to push these things forward steadily. We would also have had the energy to screen and handle information about the border and pass it safely to each city-state. Now… we can only say that time has become too short.”

“Time… yes, time has become much too short,” Duncan said softly. He knew Helena and Frem were stating helpless facts, so he did not stay on that topic. After a quiet sigh, he turned his head toward Vanna. “Then let’s talk about something else. Vanna, didn’t you have something you wanted to say to Lord Frem?”

The tall, gray-skinned Flamebearer Pope sitting across the table, Frem, froze for a moment. Then he seemed to realize something, adjusted his posture, and turned a serious gaze on Vanna.

Vanna nodded slightly, then stood up and walked toward a corner of the hall. A moment later, she returned carrying something unusually large on

her shoulder.

It was the “Gatekeeper’s cane” left by Tarrigan.

“Careful with the beams…” Duncan could not help reminding her. “And the pillars…”

Vanna nodded and carefully avoided smashing anything in the hall with the Gatekeeper’s cane, which was as thick as the trunk of a giant tree. Then she slowly laid it on the table before everyone.

“This is the ‘Chronicle Pillar’.”

Chapter 681: “Madness”?

Frem’s gaze was instantly drawn to the enormous Gatekeeper’s cane. He stared at it for a long time before finally forcing out some words: “… Everburning Ember…”

After a few more seconds of silence, he raised his head. His eyes fell on Vanna and Duncan. “You brought it out here because…”

“This was Vanna’s idea,” Duncan shook his head and stepped back half a step. “She thinks the Gatekeeper’s cane should be given to the Flamebearer Church.”

Frem’s eyes widened a little. He looked at the Inquisitor in surprise.

“Tarrigan left this Gatekeeper’s cane to me as a parting keepsake. But at that time, he did not yet know about the age of the Deep Sea,” Vanna sighed lightly and spoke in a calm tone. “Maybe the Tarrigan I saw was only a shadow. Maybe the Senkin of the Deep Sea age were only ‘replicas’ remade after the Third Long Night. But some things… belong where they belong. The legacy of a civilization should not become someone’s personal collection. Giving it to the Flamebearer Church has more meaning than keeping it in my own hands.”

The table fell quiet for a while. Helena, Rune, and Banster exchanged glances, then wisely closed their mouths. Frem slowly stretched out his hand. His fingers, rough like stone, gently stroked the coarse surface of the Gatekeeper’s cane.

The dense carvings on the Gatekeeper's cane seemed to hold frozen time, telling without words of a forgotten era of civilization. In that faded and vanished memory, a race had stumbled up from the wasteland, walked toward glory, and then toward its end.

But Frem could not recognize a single character carved there. He only felt a strange closeness in every mark, so close it felt as if they were carved into his own soul, and yet so distant it was as if they came from another dimension.

A complex emotion welled up from his heart.

"When the elves first dug out those scrolls in the Dark Islands, they felt the same as you do now," Rune suddenly broke the silence. The old elf watched the changes on Frem's face and spoke quietly. "We have gone through it once. I understand."

"…These carvings show a complete chain of script evolution. We will be able to decipher their meaning," Frem said softly. "The Flamebearer Church is expert in this field."

He suddenly lifted his head and looked into Vanna's eyes with great seriousness.

"I will take rubbings of everything carved on it and use them to study the Senkin script and history—we only need to take those."

Vanna blinked, surprised and puzzled. "Of course… but you mean, the Gatekeeper's cane…"

"This is a gift our Lord gave you. Leaving it in your hands is His will," Frem slowly shook his head. "And, Miss Vanna, the legacy of a civilization is not this Gatekeeper's cane pulled from a dream. The true legacy is here—in the history recorded by these carvings."

The Flamebearer Pope's fingers brushed lightly over the surface of the Gatekeeper's cane. In those shallow and deep grooves, his touch seemed to reach back to those ancient, lost years.

"To this day, whether we want to admit it or not, we can no longer deny what the cultists wrote in The Blasphemous Tome. The true history of our world began with the Third Long Night. Everything in the mortal world is a 'replica' created from the ashes. For a world copied from ashes… digging up 'memory' and 'history' now means far more than chasing after 'relics' themselves. Miss Vanna, we only need to take the writing from it."

Vanna blinked again. This turn of events was not what she had expected. She subconsciously looked up at Duncan. He gave her a slight nod.

"…I understand," Vanna let out a gentle breath. "Then I will keep it safe and treasure it as much as I treasure honor and life."

"Good. Then this matter is settled as well," Duncan broke the silence. He stepped forward with a faint smile on his face, but the smile quickly faded as if something had come to mind. He could not help speaking: "…But that reminds me. After Vanna brought this 'Chronicle Pillar' back into the Mortal Realm, you Flamebearer people never received any 'feedback' or 'revelation' from Tarrigan?"

"No," Frem shook his head and answered very frankly. "Just as we said earlier in the meeting, the link between the mortal world and the Gods has become abnormally difficult. Not only are the 'voices' themselves weakening, but the messages that do manage to get through are mixed with more and more interference and noise. For now, the only good news is that the 'power' that the Gods send down can still work on the Boundless Sea. Beyond that, even we four have not heard Their voices clearly for many years."

“I can only reach the Goddess’s vague revelation and, now and then, her mental guidance,” Vanna quickly added beside him. “The Goddess still answers my call very quickly, but that ‘answer’ has indeed always been hazy.”

“The decline and death of a god is a process completely different from that of a mortal,” Rune spoke up as well. “We still cannot uncover the secrets in it. But clearly, They still have reason—for now, at least. It is just that this ‘reason’ can no longer pass cleanly into mortal minds. It is as if some kind of ‘cognitive deviation’ has appeared between the two. That ‘deviation’ makes our minds less and less able to understand Their ‘voices’…”

Rune stopped there for a moment. After a brief silence, he went on with a hint of hesitation: “Frankly, this reminds me again of the story of the ‘Madbird’.”

Helena’s expression changed slightly at once. She seemed to understand Rune’s meaning right away. “You mean the nature of the Gods’ current ‘death state’ is that They are gradually drifting away from our world at the level of ‘cognition’? That the increasing interference and noise we have received from the arks over these years… is some kind of growing ‘Madbird effect’?”

“This is only a guess I came up with recently—after the Lightwind Harbor incident,” Rune nodded lightly. “It is also the only guess so far that can explain those stronger and stronger ‘noises’.”

Duncan listened quietly at the side as the Popes discussed the matter. When their talk had almost run its course, he suddenly spoke: “In fact… I was just about to say this. I can occasionally ‘hear’ Their voices, or see the messages They send.”

Helena, Frem, and the others fell silent at once.

All four Popes slowly turned their heads. Their eyes fell on Duncan, and each of their faces looked as if they had just seen a ghost—

To be fair, with their skills, they would probably be calmer if they really did see a ghost.

“Is that true?!” Helena was the first to speak. “You mean you can clearly hear the Gods’ voices? They even… send you messages?!”

Even Frem, always so steady and calm, lost his composure. The Senkin Pope, like a small giant, came around the table to stand in front of Duncan. “You have direct contact with the Gods? By what means?”

“Whoa, hold on. I said ‘occasionally’—I only hear or see Their messages once in a while,” Duncan quickly waved his hands, knowing they had misunderstood. “That does not count as ‘direct contact’. But yes… it is quite clear. To be honest, I have no idea what ‘noise’ and ‘interference’ you keep talking about—I have never run into them.”

The Popes looked at one another.

Duncan did not hide his few experiences of, by coincidence, hearing or seeing messages from the Gods. He told them about the notes he had seen, and the traces of the Gods’ conversations he had found in that strange, dark space.

Of course, he kept back the exact content of those exchanges.

Then the hall fell quiet for a long time.

At last, Frem was the first to break the silence. The steady Senkin turned his gaze to Rune. “…This seems to prove, at the very least, that They really do still have reason.”

“Yes, They are still rational,” Rune snapped out of his brief daze and began to think at once. “If this is true… and if my earlier guess is not too far

off…”

He paused, then quickly sorted out his thoughts—

“Then we can read the situation like this: the Gods still have reason, but Their ‘reason’ has already drifted away from mortal minds, and even from the world itself. So we find it hard to contact Them, and the world has begun to suffer Their corruption. But on the other hand, because of his own special nature, Captain Duncan is completely unaffected by this ‘drift’…”

Rune suddenly stopped again. He seemed to sense some vague or unexplained contradiction in his chain of thought and fell into silence. Just then, Duncan happened to think of something else.

“I remember… according to the current conclusions shared by scholars and the Church, the ‘Abyssal Lord’ in the Abyssal Deep of the Deep Sea is an Elder God in a completely mad runaway state, isn’t It?”

“Of course,” Rune answered at once without the slightest doubt. “The Abyssal Lord is, like the Black Sun, a being with no reason at all. We even have direct proof of this. Humans cannot enter the Abyssal Deep of the Deep Sea and live, but through complex and dangerous ritual, we can ‘observe’ what lies at that depth…”

“I have had a chat with the Abyssal Lord too,” Duncan shrugged. “Honestly, I think Its mental state is actually fine—though It did say It has been having a hard time lately.”

Rune: “…?”

Duncan glanced at the ghost-struck faces of the Popes and hesitated for a moment. Then he decided to keep going—after all, the mood had already come this far.

“And about that ‘Black Sun’ you just mentioned… I have seen It as well, though we only exchanged a sentence or two. It really is having trouble

holding on.”

Rune, Helena, Banster, and Frem all wore the same expression: “…?!”

Chapter 682: Starlight Overflowing

It was clear that the news Duncan suddenly revealed had shaken the Popes' whole view of the world. They stood there trying to recover for a long time, and in the end they still had not really calmed down.

After skipping over anything related to Alice's manor, Duncan briefly told Rune and the others about his talks with the Black Sun and the Abyssal Lord.

He was not worried that this information would corrupt the people here. On one hand, all his followers had already received his spirit flame baptism. That had proved they now had very high resistance to mental corruption. On the other hand, the Popes present almost dealt with mental corruption every single day. Their resistance looked very high. They were not about to go mad and start screaming just because they heard a few mutterings from the Elder Gods. If the group of bishops from earlier were still here, he would never have mentioned any of this.

Helena and the others looked at one another. After a moment of thought and hesitation, all three gazes fell on Rune.

The short, chubby old elf looked a little embarrassed at once: "…Why are you all looking at me?"

"You are the most learned among us," Helena said, her face full of sincerity.

Banster nodded: "In the deep field of occult studies, you often have unique insights and a sensitivity as sharp as a prophetic omen."

Frem said nothing. He only kept staring at Rune without blinking.

Rune stayed silent for a few seconds, his expression a bit strange. After thinking for a moment, he seemed to suddenly think of something. He turned to Duncan, who was watching the scene from the side: “You are sure you heard clear and rational voices from the Abyssal Lord and the Black Sun, right?”

“Of course I am sure,” Duncan spread his hands. “They were as rational as the way we are talking now.”

“Then the second question,” Rune said after a short pause, his face turning very serious. “Since you returned from Subspace to the Mortal Realm, have you ever run into any ‘chaotic creations’ that, in your eyes, were totally impossible to speak with or understand, completely unnamable?”

Duncan was slightly taken aback. Then he vaguely understood what the old Pope meant. After a brief silence he spoke: “…I have met many ‘chaotic, mad, uncommunicable freaks’ by mortal standards. But almost every time… I heard useful information in their noise-like roars. Sometimes I even felt they were deliberately trying to talk to me.”

He stopped there, leaving half a sentence unsaid—
[He had always thought that was normal!]

Rune’s expression clearly changed after hearing Duncan’s answer. His brows knotted at once. Beside him, Helena also reacted: “Wait, so that means…”

“…In the Captain’s eyes, there are no Elder Gods in a mad runaway state,” Rune said slowly, looking into Duncan’s eyes with a serious face. “You can understand voices that have completely left the baseline of reason in any situation. Even beings that would drive a mortal insane at a single glance are, for you, probably still understandable and open to communication.”

For a moment the hall fell silent. Except for Alice, whose brain never quite kept up, and Shirley, who never used hers, everyone began at once, almost on instinct, to think about what this meant, and to think about the ‘reason’ behind this incredible ‘phenomenon’.

While they were lost in thought, Morris spoke quietly, breaking the silence: “If we follow the ‘cognitive deviation’ idea you just raised, Teacher, then that means the Captain…”

“No matter how far everything deviates, it still stays within his range of understanding,” Rune nodded slowly. “This is a bit like… wait, wait, I need paper and a pen!”

Morris reacted at once: “Here.”

Someone quickly spread a sheet of paper on the table. Rune picked up a pencil and bent over it under everyone’s curious gaze, quickly sketching shapes across the paper. To Duncan’s surprise, they were not any complex and mysterious occult studies runes, nor any deep and hard-to-understand math formulas. What Rune drew were just one loose, seemingly random circle after another.

He drew many circular patterns. They were scattered randomly across the page. Some overlapped one another. Some only touched a little along their edges. Some were completely separate.

“Do you still remember the Great Annihilation? And the guesses about how the New World formed after the Great Annihilation…” Rune spoke quickly as he drew. “Many worlds crashed into one another. Their wreckage piled up to form the base of the New World. I call this pile of wreckage ‘Primordial Ashes’. At the very beginning, each set of ashes still carried the ‘rules’ of its own world. We can treat the ashes that share the same set of rules as one circle like this…

“Yes, the idea of sets. The Primordial Ashes left behind by each world are one subset. Do you see these circles that cross one another? The overlapping parts are the parts of the Primordial Ashes that are ‘compatible’ with each other…

“During the third Long Night, the Primordial Ashes that could fit together were rearranged. They formed the Deep Sea era we live in now… the ‘intersection’ in the sets. Yes, right here…”

Rune stopped and pointed with his pencil at the center of the sheet.

There, several large and small circles met. The overlapping parts made up an area only as big as a fingernail.

“This is our Deep Sea era,” Rune went on. “The Primordial Ashes from many pieces of world wreckage that could fit together and barely ‘hold’ under the same set of rules. Together they built the Boundless Sea, and the many city-states on the Boundless Sea…

“And outside this ‘intersection’, in the other parts of these circles that do not overlap, that is, in their ‘difference sets’, lie the things we can touch but cannot understand or control. They drift along the edges of our Mortal Realm, at the World’s Edge. They may show up as Visions, as anomalies, or as other strange phenomena—carriers of corruption…”

Rune thought for a moment, then pointed to the circles that floated outside all the others, those that did not touch any other shape at all.

“Here is where the Blasphemous Archetypes lie,” he said. “Where the Black Sun and other lost Elder Gods and exiled races are. We can no longer understand their existence at all, and they cannot fit into the Mortal Realm. Some of them have already vanished completely into the dark. Others… still drift as Primordial Ashes in some kind of time and space we cannot understand.”

Morris looked at the simple yet clear drawings his Teacher had sketched on the paper and quickly understood: “We sit inside the ‘intersection’, so we can only ‘understand’ the information inside the intersection. Things outside the intersection are, to us, unnamable noise and shadows…”

Rune nodded: “Yes. That is the ‘fact’ this model shows.”

“But for the Captain,” Morris went on, “both the strange shadows outside the intersection and the lost Elder Gods that float completely outside the system of sets are still understandable. In his eyes, there is no ‘world outside the intersection’…”

“As you say…”

Duncan stood to the side, quietly listening to the discussion.

They were talking about him, trying to use a set of logic to explain him. They were trying to know, to understand, to touch his “true secret”.

But he did not care.

He simply listened in silence, lost in thought in the Listening Rite.

His gaze rested on the diagrams Rune had drawn, gaze on the circles that crossed, overlapped, and stood alone, gaze on the Primordial Ashes drifting and scattered through this ruin, gaze on that sheet of paper.

For some reason, he suddenly recalled his recent experiences in Subspace, recalled the overflowing starlight he had seen in the eyes of those pale giants…

Vanna also walked up to that sheet of paper. She looked at the drawing on it and could not help asking softly: “Then where is the Captain on this…?”

Rune’s face grew solemn: “Only in one case can a ‘universal set’ hold all the subsets that have appeared here, and even those that have not yet appeared.”

Vanna thought for a moment and gestured on the paper: “A larger circle that includes them all?”

“No.”

Morris shook his head.

Then the old scholar stepped forward half a step and gently placed his hand on the sheet.

“It is this sheet of paper.”

As he finished speaking, he lifted his head and looked around.

Endless starlight filled his vision, filled his memories, filled his mind.

It filled the eyes of everyone in the hall.

Helena’s eyes widened in the starlight. In the towering wave raised by the Truth, she felt her mind on the verge of collapse. She saw a shifting shadow, a shape, swell up in the sea of starlight. The outline drew close to her, roaring—

“Isn’t it unbelievable?”

Rune stood stiff in the starlight. Noise and trembling squeezed out from his reason: “Truth… so beautiful…”

Then all the starlight suddenly vanished. The vast, rising and falling shadow shrank and collapsed in an instant that no human could sense, turning back into the Mortal Realm hall.

Vanna barely broke free from the terrifying afterimage left by the starlight. Through the strong dizziness, she saw the Captain walk to the table and slowly roll up the sheet of paper.

“Here is a suggestion for you,” Duncan turned his head and looked into Rune’s eyes. “Next time you want to discuss me, make more preparations

first.”

The horrible afterimages left by the starlight finally faded away completely. Duncan had already rolled the sheet up and casually stuffed it inside his clothes.

As the Truth was covered for the moment, reason suddenly returned to everyone’s mind.

Banster drew in a deep breath and stepped back without thinking. Then he glared at Rune: “I should have kept my distance from ‘scholars’ like you from the very start!”

“You were the ones who asked me to analyze it!” Rune panted twice, first giving Duncan a fearful glance, then looking at Banster and the other two. “You tell me, did it work or not?”

“Captain…” Morris turned to Duncan, an awkward look on his face. “Sorry…”

“It is fine. Curiosity is human nature,” Duncan said with a laugh, his smile as gentle and forgiving as ever. “The good thing is that no one died.”

Chapter 683: Extinguished Again

By now, everyone who stayed here finally had a deeper understanding of the Master of the Vanished—at least from the goal of “knowing more and talking better”, they had achieved half of it.

Sadly, the mood turned awkward right after this “better understanding”.

A strange silence sat over the hall. The Popes, including Helena, seemed unsure whether they should keep the topic going. Vanna and Morris still looked a bit tense. Shirley was calming the uneasy Dog. Nina, on the other hand, looked at Duncan with some curiosity—the sudden starlight had not affected her at all.

Lucretia looked at everyone in the hall with a half smile. For some reason there was even a bit of gloating in that smile.

Only Alice—the doll Miss—still kept her usual vacant, faraway look, lost in her own world. She had already been spacing out for some time. Back when Rune started using the idea of “sets” to explain the world, she had switched off her brain. After quite a while, she suddenly seemed to react, looking around in surprise and confusion: “It’s over? Are we getting ready for dinner?”

This out-of-sync line from the doll Miss finally broke the awkward silence. Banster lifted his head, his gaze landing on Duncan. After several seconds he could not hold back: “…What exactly was that just now?”

As soon as he finished speaking, Frem, who stood closest to him, instantly took several steps to the side.

“…I was only asking,” Banster glanced at Helena and Rune, who had also stepped aside, and shook his head helplessly.

“I have many secrets on me, some of which even I do not really understand,” Duncan said, not minding at all. He only shook his head helplessly, then looked at Rune on the opposite side, his expression serious. “But I am very grateful for the ideas you and Morris just raised… your line of thought helped me clear up a bit of confusion.”

“…Then I hope next time you clear up some confusion you can give us a warning first,” Rune said, a bit helpless. “Though I know that sounds a bit unreasonable.”

Duncan laughed: “…I will do my best.”

This dangerous topic finally ended, but the thoughts stirred up by Rune’s “set model” still lingered in many hearts. Duncan went back to his seat and touched his pocket. His fingers brushed the folded sheet of paper again—

Primordial Ashes, the “intersection” of world rules, the conflict between what could and could not fit together, the viewpoint of an observer inside a subset, and…

He drew his hand out of his pocket and let out a soft breath.

Lucretia could not help looking at Duncan.

A groundless feeling of dread suddenly rose up, making her heart pound a few times. She looked toward her Father on instinct, yet she felt that in that very instant, in the moment her gaze turned over, Father had… already not been there.

He had gone somewhere very, very far away, so far he was no longer in this world. In that brief moment… Lucretia felt again what she had felt a century ago, when she watched the Vanished enter the thick fog at the border.

But it was only a short illusion. When she blinked again, Duncan was still sitting there as before, as if he had never moved at all.

“So then, what other questions do you have?” Duncan raised his head and looked at Helena, Rune, and the others who had also just sat back down on the other side of the table.

Alice scratched her hair and sat back down next to Duncan: “Oh, so it isn’t over yet.”

Across from them, Rune gave Alice a subtle look, then slightly gathered his thoughts. But just as he was about to say something, he suddenly stopped.

He frowned a little, as if he were tilting his head to listen to a voice from far away through a Listening Rite. Seeing this, Helena reacted at once: “Is there news coming in?”

“Psychic Communication from Lightwind Harbor. Ted Lier is contacting me,” Rune looked up, his face already turning grave. “He says the research facility set up near that ‘glowing geometric body’ suddenly received some signals being released from inside the glowing orb…”

As he spoke, his gaze fell on Lucretia.

“They are exactly the same as the signal the Radiant Star picked up when the Sun went out last time.”

Lucretia stood up at once.

It was now dusk—the Sun had not yet completely set.

Vision 001 was slowly sinking toward the sea surface. The two brilliant glowing rune rings had about one-third of their shape touching the distant ocean. sunlight built a magnificent sunset between sea and sky, and the glow scattered a fine layer of gold over the whole sea.

In another direction, in the offshore waters of Lightwind Harbor, the huge glowing geometric body still floated quietly on the sea surface. Another patch of pale golden “sunlight” spread out evenly from the geometric figure over the surrounding sea, with it at the center. It built a unique view of “two different kinds of sunlight crossing and weaving between sea and sky”.

The “sunlight” coming out of that glowing geometric body was warm and calm, looking no different from any other time.

Yet, according to the records of high-sensitivity instruments, certain specific spectra in that “sunlight” were now “vibrating” in a very complex pattern, periodically sending out wave signals that were hard to understand.

Duncan and the others went to the aft deck and looked, through the crisscrossing sunset glow, at the huge glowing geometric body near Lightwind Harbor.

Frem looked at Rune and spoke in a deep voice: “Is the signal still going?”

“It is still going. The signal has a cycle of twelve seconds. It repeats three times, then pauses for thirty seconds before appearing again,” Rune nodded. “Ted Lier has already reached the research station. He is monitoring the equipment there himself…”

“The cycle and repeating pattern are the same as last time.”

Lucretia said this quickly while raising her head to glance at the nearby sea. Her Radiant Star was quietly docked beside the Vanished, and at this moment a special structure on top of the ship’s bridge was slowly rotating —

A pod shaped like a mechanical flower bud was turning one side of itself toward the distant sea. The covers at the front of the pod opened, and the precise optical lens hidden inside gleamed in the sunlight.

“I am ordering the servants left on the ship to open the optical lens on the Radiant Star,” Lucretia watched the movement of her flagship while explaining to Duncan beside her. “Back when the Sun went out, I was the first one to notice the strange light signal. Only after that did Lightwind Harbor build similar devices and install them at the research facility… In theory, if the station can see the signal, we should be able to see it from here too.”

“The distance doesn’t affect it?” Nina asked in surprise.

“Light does weaken and it can be disturbed, but at this distance it is still fine—the real question now is what this strange signal means,” Lucretia said, brow furrowed, her tone worried. “Last time the signal appeared after the Sun went out. But this time the signal appeared while the Sun still looks fine…”

“Let us move closer to Lightwind Harbor first and make sure nothing goes wrong with the city-state,” Duncan said. As his words fell, the Vanished had already begun to turn its bow and slowly pick up speed toward Lightwind Harbor.

Beside it, the Radiant Star received Lucretia’s orders after a slight delay and reacted the same way.

Rune watched with some surprise the nimble movements of the Radiant Star, and the “test pod” above the bridge making “synchronized responses” as the hull changed its angle. He could not help sighing: “What a clever design… Lady Lucretia, did you build all this yourself?”

“I spent a hundred years designing a ‘vanguard exploration ship’ that could carry out border missions in any situation. There are many parts of this ship I am proud of,” Lucretia said lightly. “But you still have the mood to analyze the engineering on the Radiant Star right now?”

“We do not have anything else to do anyway,” Rune shrugged, looking not nervous at all. “If anything, I am a bit excited. A strange phenomenon has appeared, and it is in a field I have never touched. If we can really crack the secret of the signals coming from that glowing geometric body, we may get a real chance to understand what is going on with the ‘Sun’ above our heads. That is a good thing.”

Lucretia did not answer. She had already moved most of her focus to the Radiant Star, to the “servants” left on the ship.

All those servants were made by her own hand. Each servant held a fragment of her soul inside. Every servant, even the whole ship, was like an extension of her body.

She carefully gave orders and set all the complex and precise observation devices on the Radiant Star into motion.

“…The signal is stronger than what I saw last time,” she suddenly raised her head and looked toward the pale golden sunlight spread over the sea. “The situation does not seem quite the same as before…”

Duncan looked in another direction—toward the Sun, Vision 001, which was slowly sinking and already had a third of its structure below the sea surface.

“Last time the Sun went out…” Shirley’s nervous voice came from the side. She looked quite uneasy. “At least this time, no matter what, the Sun does not seem to have changed yet…”

She only got halfway through her sentence.

A low humming sound suddenly seemed to ring in the bottom of everyone’s hearts.

A strange feeling of unease cut off all conversation.

The distant sky suddenly darkened.

Shirley’s face went blank as she lifted her head and looked toward the darkening sky.

A dark, chaotic sphere like a hollow, and two ring-shaped “bright rims” like red-hot steel, hung there, motionless at the edge of the sky.

The Sun had gone out again.

“…Crap.”

Chapter 684: veil of night – Lost

Once again, the Sun went out before Duncan and the others.

A strange low rumble came first. Then, just as the Sun was about to sink below the sea's horizon, all light vanished from its surface. It turned into a terrifying black hole in the sky. The two rune rings around the Sun still seemed to shine with sunlight. They became two blinding bright rims around that dark hole.

A thin, limited glow spread from the dead edge of the Sun, leaving a layer of murky light between the sky and the sea. That dim light only made the sky look more eerie and frightening.

As the Sun went out, the distant Boundless Sea fell into darkness. Only the "glowing geometric body" near Lightwind Harbor kept shining with its usual "sunlight," holding a basic light over a small area of ocean. The rays of light spilling out across the water became the only comforting thing under the strange "veil of night."

Shirley was completely stunned. She stared into the distance, unable to squeeze out a second sentence. Nina beside her recovered first. She reached out and patted her friend on the shoulder and said: "Don't panic, okay? There's no way it went out just because you said it would…"

"Of course I know that!" Shirley almost jumped up. Then she quickly turned her eyes toward Duncan not far away and said: "Captain, what do we do?"

“Lightwind Harbor is still there. The Pilgrimage Arks are still there…” Duncan did not answer Shirley. He looked at the direction of Lightwind Harbor right away. Under the glow of the glowing geometric body, he carefully studied the distant sea. From here, he could clearly see the coastline of Lightwind Harbor and the outline of the huge Storm Cathedral moored near the city-state.

The other three Pilgrimage Arks could not be seen in full from this angle, but it was clear they were also still in place.

“So… this is ‘the Sun going out’…” Rune muttered. After the first shock passed, he finally reacted. “This really happened…”

Banster stared hard at the terrifying black hole hanging over the sea’s surface far away. His voice was low and heavy as he said: “The aura of the Spirit Realm is starting to grow restless, but the World’s Wound has not appeared ahead of time.”

Duncan looked toward the Popes and said: “I remember you said that last time the Sun went out, the four Pilgrimage Arks didn’t notice anything?”

“Yes.” Rune nodded. “According to what you told us, we stayed still together with the rest of the world during those twelve ‘missing’ hours. We simply ‘skipped’ the event of the Sun going out. If we hadn’t later received reports from Lightwind Harbor, Frostholm, and Pland, we wouldn’t have known anything had happened.”

Duncan nodded slowly, his gaze still fixed on the distant city. “But now you’ve seen it. Your Pilgrimage Arks are here too. Everyone has seen it.”

“What is the principle behind this?” Rune spoke without thinking. He looked at the huge glowing geometric body hanging over the nearby sea and grew thoughtful. “Is it because the four Pilgrimage Arks are now also inside that thing’s protection range?”

“It may really be connected to that strange glowing geometric body,” Duncan said with a nod. “Pland, Frostholm, and Lightwind Harbor each had some special trait that let them ‘remain’ when the Sun went out. Lightwind Harbor’s biggest trait is that it is always bathed in this strange ‘sunlight.’

“But this is not the time to discuss it. You should check the situation on the four Arks at once. Also, Lucretia, can you contact the city now?”

“There is a radio on the Radiant Star. We have already contacted Lightwind Harbor,” Lucretia said, nodding at once. “The city-state has sounded the emergency alarm. Constable units and the knowledge guards are already working to keep order. We shouldn’t have to worry for a while.”

“Order isn’t the problem. Panic is,” Vanna muttered nearby. “And the panic this time won’t be the same as last time. After all, not long after the Sun went out last time, the Nameless One’s Dream broke out…”

Her words brought silence to the deck. Under the dim sky, everyone looked at each other. Their faces showed a mix of subtle, serious, and uneasy expressions.

The four Popes moved quickly. They contacted their own Pilgrimage Arks at once and checked on each Ark’s condition. They gave orders from afar, telling the priests left on the Arks to keep order, monitor the situation, and gather information. At the same time, they ordered each Ark to send some priests into Lightwind Harbor to help control public security and calm the Residents’ fear.

Meanwhile, Duncan and his group returned to the central deck area. There, they found the Bishop groups in some confusion.

These Bishops had been sent out of the meeting early. In the last few minutes, they had gained memories they would never forget. They had just started to get used to the strange, uncanny environment aboard the

Vanished, used to all the “living things” and suspicious “rules” on this ship. After the meeting, they had come out on deck to eat a few snacks and enjoy the sea breeze to relax their nerves.

They had barely relaxed when—snap—the Sun went out.

No one had even warned them first.

Thanks to the emergency “training” before boarding and the “common sense lessons” after coming aboard, at least half of the Bishops, on seeing the Sun go out, instinctively wondered if this might count as another “natural phenomenon” that could be seen from the Vanished. When Duncan led a large group into the central deck area, a few Bishops were still deep in discussion.

Their main topic was how early it got dark on the Vanished.

Luckily, after some frantic communication and explanations from all sides, everyone understood what was really happening. They quickly recovered from their first wave of confusion and panic, and order returned.

Under the dim sky and the faint “sunlight” spilling from far away, the Vanished and the Radiant Star once more increased their speed and sailed toward the coastline of Lightwind Harbor.

…

At the semi-permanent floating island research station beside the glowing geometric body, Ted Riel and several Scholars stood together in the upper observation room. Their faces were grave as they watched a radio set. The radio was carrying the latest news from inside the city-state.

The Sun going out had caused a short burst of citywide panic. After that, the Constable units and the Guardians quickly brought order back under control. All main districts inside the city had now entered a state of martial

law. The main roads were blocked. Every Sanctuary World was open. Gas lamps were lit early, and the bells of the Academy drifted over the city.

For now, there was no sign of supernatural corruption invading the city. No districts had reported people falling into mental corruption or undergoing any mental transformation.

The good news was that this was not the first time Lightwind Harbor had faced the Sun going out. People were no longer as unprepared as they had been before. They did not suffer so many needless losses in chaotic panic.

The bad news was that after the Sun went out last time, the terrible event known as the Nameless One's Dream had followed. The lingering Shadows of that horror still hung over the city-state.

Even though order inside the city had quickly settled, fear and unease in people's hearts were quietly growing. Everyone worried what might happen after the Sun went out this time.

Ted Riel knew that such wide-spreading fear was the hardest thing to handle. It could not be controlled, and it could not be ignored. It swelled like a dark tide until the crisis ended—or turned into another great disaster.

But that was not the only problem.

Ted Riel frowned and looked toward a machine at the far end of the room.

A recorder was clattering as it ran. Fine gears and rods drove a steel needle back and forth along its track. A long paper strip slowly fed out of the machine. Thin black lines jumped on the strip, drawing information no Human mind could understand.

The signal came every twelve seconds. It repeated three times, then stopped for thirty seconds before starting again.

The recorder was linked to a complex optical device mounted before the observation window at the far end of the room.

“The light-signal from the glowing orb is still going,” a Scholar beside Ted said. “At the moment the Sun went out, the signal clearly grew stronger. It has already passed the highest value in our records.

“Also, a backup unit set in the upper station just received a very weak signal. The signal is the same as the one we get here. That backup unit is aimed at the Sun, the one that has gone dark.”

“This is clearly a complete system,” another Scholar could not help saying. “The Sun and the glowing geometric body that fell into the mortal world still have some kind of link, even if they seem to have separated on the surface…”

“There is still no progress in decoding,” a third Scholar said softly. “If only some new pattern would appear in these signals. At least then we could use it for cross-checking.”

“News just came from the city towers. They have confirmed that the Sun has stopped moving. It is fixed just above the sea surface and has not moved any lower in the last half hour…”

“No one went up the towers to look at the Sun again, right?!” someone blurted out.

“No,” came the answer. “The instruments are recording automatically. The staff only read the data indirectly. Ever since the last incident, the Academy has strictly forbidden anyone to observe the Sun directly in a case like this…”

Ted Riel listened to the talk around him, his brow tightly furrowed. He stayed silent. After a long time deep in thought, he suddenly lifted his head and said: “I have to return to the city-state.”

“Yes, you need to go back to help keep order,” a Scholar said at once. “Leave this place to us. No matter what happens, the observation station will keep running. We will not miss any data.”

Ted Riel looked at these Scholars who carried such weight and trust in their fields. He nodded silently, then opened the Book of sacred miracles that held so many spells and pieces of knowledge.

He turned to the section that recorded “Door” and tapped the page with his finger.

A ghostly great door rose out of the book and formed in the air before him. It opened without a sound.

He took a breath and stepped into the door.

Boundless darkness and chaos swallowed all his senses—

He did not arrive in Lightwind Harbor.

Chapter 685: Dark Passage

The instant that boundless darkness and chaos rushed over him, Ted Riel knew something was wrong.

When he tried to cancel the teleportation at once and step back through the “door,” he found his power did not answer him. The ghostly door that had been at his side only a second ago had already vanished into the endless dark and chaos.

Calm down.

As a Truth Keeper, he drew a slow breath. In the shortest time, he forced himself to calm down. He held back his instinct to start observing and sensing everything around him. In the dark, he stood still where he was. He did not try to see or hear anything.

He slowly pulled his senses back in and held his own thoughts under tight control. Using the “mental discipline” he had trained for many years, he pushed down his natural mortal curiosity, his drive to explore, and his habit of making connections.

This would help him resist any hostile power that might exist in this place. It would also keep him from reaching out too quickly for “knowledge” he was not ready to touch.

Rahm taught that countless truths lay hidden in the dark. In darkness, anything could appear—but the things that did not harm mortals were less than one in ten thousand.

The numbness in his mind slowly spread and turned into a wall that shielded his thoughts. The Blessing of Folly given by Rahm had come. Ted Riel let out a light breath and felt a bit more at ease. Only then did he begin to hold on to the bare minimum of reason and judgment, while carefully rebuilding his senses. He lifted his gaze toward what seemed like endless chaos.

Murky, dreamlike Shadows filled his sight. The darkness looked like a boundless wasteland, and at the same time like a forest of countless towering, unnamable giants. Some huge structure jumped at the edge of his vision. It seemed to float above that wasteland, drifting blind and confused.

A sharp, brutal headache struck him.

For a moment, Ted almost could not stand. The defenses and caution he had built with all his strength shattered in a single second. The instant he saw those giant shapes, countless sharp, tiny, dizzying noises flooded up from the depths of his mind. They tore at his reason like endless cruel saw-teeth. They scraped away his personality and began to eat all his humanity, logic, and memories.

Streams of dim, chaotic light flashed between the floating giants. With that flash, a thought rose in his heart, one strong enough to shake even the firmest Saint into despair—

Subspace.

“Not good…”

Ted Riel only managed to squeeze out one word from his mind before he felt himself losing control of his own body. He felt strange limbs growing from his back, and some thick, icy liquid flowing in his veins. His vision split in the darkness. Countless wild viewpoints he could not control swept

around, staring into the dark from every angle. The roaring noise almost crushed his reason—

Then, in the next second, his powerful will surged up from deep inside. He hurried to seal off those alien senses and shred the alien voices in his head. He branded his own identity as an Elf over and over again into his heart.

In that brief moment of forced clarity, he suddenly felt a power appear—and with it, an illusion took shape before him.

He saw a flickering red light like a cold, rational single eye floating in the dark. Many smaller lights flashed around it in neat rows, like an array. A huge outline like a silent tombstone rose behind those lights, standing still in a mist that had appeared from nowhere.

All of Ted's remaining reason was drawn to those lights. Without thinking, he lifted his head and let his gaze fall on that glow. His thoughts were combed, reshaped, and pulled toward that lord of wisdom—

Rumble—

A phantom roar shook him out of the vision. The lights vanished before his eyes. He was back in the dark, chaotic place.

He understood what had happened.

The protection of the God of Wisdom had come. For a brief instant, Rahm had cast him a single glance.

His mind was protected—but only for a time.

A faint noise slowly rose again from the depths of his heart. Ted Riel saw twisted, jumping Shadows creeping back into his vision. He knew at once he had no time to waste. He pulled the Book of sacred miracles from his robe and tried to construct a new door back to the Mortal Realm.

But then, an unseen force came from nowhere. He felt his body suddenly lift away from the wasteland in the dark and get pulled swiftly through the darkness.

In the dark, he watched that chaotic wasteland retreat fast from his sight.

He saw the silent giants rush toward him, then pass through his field of view in indescribable twists, swellings, and shrinkings, and vanish into the far edge of space.

He saw an upside-down mass in the sky surge toward him like a crushing blow, then fade away without a sound like a mirage.

He felt that, for a time, he had stopped somewhere.

In a daze, he lifted his head and saw an immense upside-down shape almost right before him. It looked like a grand yet gloomy building, with northern-style spires and eaves. He could just make out a dry fountain and a dead garden. Parts of the building were broken apart, as if some unseen power had eaten and torn them away.

In the next second, that fine western mansion turned into a shattered giant ship. It was nothing like any “ship” he knew. It looked more like a twisted, broken metal tube built from heaps of steel. It was clearly not whole, like a piece torn off some even larger structure.

Ted Riel had no time to study this shocking thing. In the next moment, he felt himself racing again through the empty void. Light and shadow, more broken and chaotic than before, surged over him like a tidal wave, filling his sight.

With those lights and shadows came knowledge.

Knowledge he had never touched before, but that now suddenly became clear and bright in his mind.

He saw torn structures of time and space. He saw warped stars squeezed into long rings under endless pressure, then turning into eternal flashes of light at the moment of their destruction, flowing like chaos in the depths of this space.

He saw the laws of math collapse at the end of time, and ancient stars out of control, torn into countless burning fragments.

He saw a ship wandering aimlessly in the dark. The ship was decayed and almost broken. It slid through the darkness as if on some eternal mission of exploration—or as if it were only a reflection from a far-off time and space. The ship looked familiar.

Then he saw a huge thing floating at the center of the endless void.

It was a vast throne, as if carved from gray-white stone. The base around the throne was shattered. A headless body sat upon it, keeping eternal silence in the dark.

This journey was about to reach its end—

For some reason, that thought flashed through Ted Riel’s heart. It was as if he had stepped beyond the rules of time and already seen the place where he would finally stop.

Then he stopped.

He seemed to be standing on a small, broken patch of ground. There was a person there—or something else—wrapped in Shadows.

Beside it lay a small heap of melted, shapeless remains. The figure that looked like a Human, yet had some strange half-formed structure, leaned against that heap. It was like a soldier who had died here in some age beyond memory, one hand slightly raised, pointing into the distance.

Ted Riel's mind was drawn to this figure against his will. Compared with the countless gigantic things in this chaotic space, this figure looked especially ordinary and harmless.

But just as he was about to take a step forward, a great warning burst in his heart. He stopped at once.

Right then, a faint, ghostly great door appeared beside him.

It was the teleportation gate he had summoned before, the one he had somehow "lost."

Ted Riel cast aside all hesitation in an instant. He forced himself to look away from the figure and crushed the urge to explore this unknown place. He turned and rushed straight into the ghostly door.

Passing through the door seemed to take only a moment, yet also felt like drifting for a century in chaos. Ted had never thought that a teleportation gate he summoned himself could tear him apart like this.

As his reason wavered on the edge of collapse, he dimly heard a voice at his ear. It was the sound of Humans speaking.

"I got him! Captain, I got him!"

A hoarse voice shouted, excited and proud.

A strong pull came from his arm. In his daze, Ted Riel felt someone grab him and drag him with all their strength. He heard the rise and fall of waves. He felt icy seawater soaking his limbs. A brute force hauled him out of the water onto a deck and threw him down on a hard surface.

"I caught him! This thing was drifting around on the edge of the dark… Yeah, it's a person! This thing is a person!"

Who was shouting? So rough and rude… He didn't sound like someone from the city-state. The voice was strange…

“He still seems out cold… Should I do mouth-to-mouth? Ah, now I’m nervous… Wait, Captain, I don’t even breathe… I only pretend to breathe for the mood… Should I still try?”

Who on earth was that?

Ted Riel struggled to think. He started to “reboot” his senses and every nerve in his body. He forced himself awake and tried his best to open his eyes.

In the darkness, the blurred, wavering shapes around him finally began to grow clear.

He saw the one who had been shouting. He saw a face, very close to his own.

It was an ugly mummified corpse. A horrifying face that looked as if it would rot into dust at any moment.

The mummified corpse was bending closer…

In that instant, Ted Riel suddenly felt that going back to Subspace might have been the better choice.

Chapter 686: Accidents and Coincidence

With a loud bang, the ugly, shriveled mummified corpse shot up from the deck and crashed into a pile of junk not far away like a cannonball.

The sailors on the deck jumped at the noise. Lawrence, who had been watching from a platform nearby, jumped down at once and led a group of men running toward where the “sailor” had fallen. In the middle of the scattered debris, the shriveled corpse in a sailor’s smock was struggling hard. He finally managed to pull his head out of a crate he had smashed through. Seeing the seafarers crowding around him, he shook his head in a daze and mumbled: “I… I saw…”

The first mate, Gus, grabbed the mummified corpse and hauled him out as he asked: “What did you see?”

“I saw my great-grandmother…”

The first mate kicked the mummified corpse straight back into the junk: “You’re a damned anomaly. Where would you get a great-grandmother?!”

Lawrence was sure at once that Anomaly 077 was fine. He turned away and walked over to the “man overboard” they had just hauled up.

An elf in southern-style clothes was half lying on the deck, leaning against the winch used to pull cargo. His expression was dull and blank. He was soaked from head to toe and looked miserable, but there were no obvious wounds on his body.

But when Lawrence came closer, the elf's reaction was clearly not normal. He only turned his head a little, very slowly, as if he was still not fully awake. His dull gaze swept around him once, then turned away again.

Ted Riel was still sunk in a fog, not knowing where he was.

Ever since he had instinctively swatted away that ugly, shriveled mummified corpse, he had stayed like this. His head felt stuffed with a thick, sticky paste of confusion. Strange noises echoed deep in his mind. Shadows shook nonstop at the edge of his vision, disturbing his judgement and his thoughts.

He knew he had already left Subspace. The sea wind and the sound of waves around him were clearly from the Mortal Realm. But that terrible "journey through the dark" had left a long, burning scar in his sanity. The scar was slowly spreading, turning into a dreadful aftereffect of having seen Subspace, and it kept numbing his nerves.

He was already very lucky. Almost no one survived after seeing Subspace, let alone went through one of those terrible "transits" and still came back to the Mortal Realm with a human mind. But he had no time to feel any joy at surviving. The last bit of reason he still had urged him to wake up as soon as possible, to pin his mind firmly to the Mortal Realm. The deadly corruption and shadows had not fully faded. They were attacking from gaps that humans could not sense or understand, trying to drag him back into that dark, chaotic place…

A buzzing, rumbling sound came from the side. It sounded like thunder heard through a thick Veil. Someone walked toward him, a strong old man with graying hair. The man seemed to be talking. His mouth opened and closed, but the sounds that came out could not be understood by human ears.

“Wake up, wake up.” Lawrence reached out and patted the stranger elf’s face, trying to rouse this poor soul who had somehow been drifting on the sea. “What is your name?”

A hazy shadow appeared at his side. Martha’s shadow whispered a warning: “Be careful, Lawrence. The way this person appeared is very suspicious. He drifted here from the sea after the Sun went out. We still don’t know what he really is…”

“Don’t worry, Martha. Even if he’s something that floated out of Subspace, he can’t be stranger than we are,” Lawrence said offhand. But he still stayed careful and put one hand on the pistol at his waist. Thin threads of dim green flame jumped in the cylinder. “When he came out from the edge of the darkness just now, did you see it clearly? How did he show up?”

“There was no prophetic omen,” Martha’s shadow answered quietly. She watched the suspicious elf, who had his eyes open but did not look truly awake. “From the moment the Sun went out, I’ve been watching the area from the Spirit Realm. He just appeared all of a sudden. A fellow like this rose from nowhere in the dark.”

“This is the first time I’ve seen something like this…”

Lawrence muttered to himself. He looked up without thinking and glanced past the rail at the choppy waves around the White Oak. A small patch of sea was lit by the light the White Oak was giving off, and in that patch the ocean still looked like it had before the Sun went out. But beyond that narrow area lay an invisible border. Outside it, the Boundless Sea was dark and eerie, as if the whole world had become nothing but emptiness.

And this suspicious elf had suddenly come out of that invisible border.

At that moment, the “drifter” leaning against the winch suddenly moved his eyes.

Lawrence snapped his head back and stared straight at him.

The elf opened his mouth, but what reached Lawrence's ears was a string of hoarse noise that humans could not understand, or even make: "@##? %…?"

Lawrence: "…?!"

The instant he heard those sounds, a warning flared in his heart. The experience he had gained from drifting on the Boundless Sea for most of his life made the old captain step back two paces at once. His revolver was in his hand so fast it was barely visible to the eye.

Almost at the same time, the sailors on watch around them reacted as well. All kinds of weapons swung up together and aimed at the drifter. Even the "sailor" who had just climbed out of the junk pile managed to pull a curved blade out from somewhere and wave it around at the side.

The drifter on the deck stared wide-eyed, clearly confused for a moment. He spread his hands to show he had no weapon, then spoke again. The same hoarse, piercing noise burst out, a sound that seemed like it could grind an ordinary person's mind to pieces: "%&**%?!!"

Then he stopped short.

Ted Riel finally realized that what he was making was not human language at all. It was not even a language.

It was a vibration even he himself could not understand, a sound without meaning.

It was an echo of Subspace.

He reacted at once. In the next second he noticed the world in front of him starting to twist. Shadows rose and shrank on the bodies of the seafarers gathered around him, who had looked like ordinary, innocent people.

Behind the white?haired old captain, countless hostile eyes appeared. The nearby deck slowly softened and turned to something like thick mud. An invisible Veil was slowly opening. The corruption of Subspace was about to…

Yet just as Ted Riel was about to carry out a sacrificial rite on himself to stop the Subspace rift from opening any further, a ghost?green flame suddenly caught his eye.

A pale spirit?form fire rose on Lawrence's body. Then the flame, like a living thing, jumped and spread out. It flared up on every nearby sailor, burning on them and turning them into ghost?like shapes. Then it rushed along the deck, along the ropes, the bridge, the smokestack…

The mummified corpse who had been waving his curved blade at the side and joining the fun let out a scream the moment the spirit flame surged up. He hopped away as if he had been burned, but soon came swaggering back, pretending nothing had happened. He carefully touched a small flame on the deck with his blade, lit a tiny fire seed on the tip, raised it over his head, and pretended that he too was part of the burning fire.

The gate of Subspace was banished before it could open. Ted Riel felt all the noise and all the shadows inside him scorched and driven away by that invisible fire. The flame cut off Subspace's last hold on him. The feel of the Mortal Realm had never been so clear and steady.

He stared up in shock at the old captain, whose whole body was wrapped in faint green flames, and felt a little dazed.

[Why does this fire look so familiar?]

"What was that just now?" Lawrence was a little dazed too. He muttered as he kept a wary eye on the elf across from him, who looked suspicious but

not like a cultist or some filthy demon. He was not sure what he should do next. “Some kind of spell?”

“…Who are you people?” Ted Riel suddenly spoke. This time, he made sounds that humans could understand. “Where is this place?”

“You can talk?!” Lawrence was startled. But when he heard the elf speak in human language, he could not help but let out a breath. He still had no idea what had happened, but the danger in his heart faded a little. “…This is the White Oak. I am her captain.”

“The White Oak?” Ted Riel frowned slightly. He seemed to vaguely remember hearing that name before. But his mind was still in a haze after all the blows and the deep exhaustion, so he could not recall the details of the ship for a moment. “What is your relationship with the Vanished? What is your relationship with Captain Duncan?”

“Captain Duncan?” Lawrence froze. This was the first time he had heard anyone outside say that name so calmly. But he soon reacted and nodded. “He is my boss.”

Ted Riel: “…?”

…

“Ted Riel is missing?!”

Inside the witch’s mansion in Lightwind Harbor, Duncan had just returned to the city. He was shocked when he heard the news Lucretia brought.

“Yes. The message just came from the Academy,” Lucretia said with a nod. She had gone out a few minutes earlier. “Fifteen minutes ago, Ted Riel left the research station next to the glowing geometric body. He left through a teleportation gate, but after that he did not appear at the planned arrival point in Lightwind Harbor.”

“Only fifteen minutes?” Shirley leaned in from the side. “That doesn’t sound that long. We can just go look for him…”

“Moving through a teleportation gate… if the person does not arrive the instant the gate opens, then something has already gone wrong,” Lucretia said as she glanced at Shirley. “This is most likely a spell runaway caused by the Sun going out.”

Chapter 687: Settling In and Conversation

The Sun going out could make teleportation spells run wild and cause people to vanish from the Mortal Realm?

After hearing Lucretia's analysis, Duncan felt a wave of doubt. But this world already held so many strange and eerie things, and the Sun going out was the strangest of them all. At this point, nothing that happened really counted as surprising. The most important thing now was to figure out where that "Truth Keeper" had gone.

Just then, Duncan suddenly frowned. It was as if he had heard some message from far away. His expression turned odd.

Alice, who was closest to him, noticed at once: "Eh? Captain, what's wrong?"

Duncan looked up. With a strange look, he glanced at Lucretia and Morris, who were still talking about how to search for Ted: "…Ahem. There's no need to look."

Lucretia and Morris: "Huh?"

"He's fine," Duncan said, waving his hand. "Ted Riel is on the White Oak right now."

Everyone in the room looked at each other. After a few seconds of silence, Vanna finally broke it: "…The White Oak? Lawrence's ship? How did he end up there?!"

“We don’t know yet. It seems even Ted Riel himself can’t explain it clearly,” Duncan said with a sigh. He kept his link with Lawrence open in his mind as he spoke. “Just like last time, the White Oak was still at sea when the Sun went out. The sailors on board saw Ted Riel drifting at the ‘dark border’ on the sea’s surface, and then Anomaly 077 fished him up…

“Lawrence says Ted’s mental state was in complete chaos at first. He could not even talk to anyone. He is only starting to recover now. It seems he went somewhere very, very far away. From his broken descriptions, it sounds like…”

Duncan stopped there, and his face grew a little more serious.

“It seems to be Subspace.”

Ted Riel was wrapped in a thick blanket and sat in a brightly lit cabin. Someone handed him a cup of hot tea that was still almost too hot to hold. He cupped it in both hands, looked up, and said: “Thank you.”

The shriveled, frightening mummified corpse stood in front of him and waved a hand. “Just don’t hit me flying again next time. If these bones break, I don’t know if they’ll ever heal right.”

Ted Riel’s expression turned complicated at once, as if he had just remembered something unpleasant. He gave the “anomaly” a stiff, embarrassed smile. The fellow was clearly in a special runaway state, yet he moved around the White Oak like an ordinary crew member, working hard all over the ship. In the end, Ted could not hold back and asked: “You are Anomaly 077, the sailor?”

“Hey, you know me?” The mummified corpse brightened at once. He leaned closer as he spoke. “Every other ordinary person who sees me just gets scared out of their wits. But you even know my name and my number?”

“…I am the Truth Keeper of Lightwind Harbor,” Ted Riel said calmly, watching the mummified corpse sit down beside him. “Years ago, I was the one who signed your transfer papers.”

The mummified corpse had just started to sit when he sprang back up again. He stared at Ted Riel, pointing at him with a bony finger, his whole body trembling with excitement: “You… you, you… you’re from the Church?! You…”

“Calm down, Mr. mummified corpse,” Ted Riel said helplessly, clearly having expected this reaction. “I know you’re a special runaway?state anomaly now. Don’t worry. I’m not going to force you back into—”

He did not even finish before the mummified corpse dropped to the floor with a thump. The corpse reached out with a bony hand, grabbed the edge of the blanket, and wailed in a voice that could freeze the heart: “I’ve been waiting for someone from the Church for so long! Please seal me! A rope that actually works is enough! If that’s too much trouble, just give me a piece of the shroud and I’ll wrap myself… or you can hit me even harder than you did just now…”

Ted Riel had never imagined a scene like this. The mummified corpse’s shrieking and wailing threw him into a panic. He clutched the blanket and scooted back while he babbled: “Stop, stop, stop… calm down… don’t pull… that’s not what I meant… we can talk about this, but you need to calm down first. You can’t just decide to be resealed by saying it out loud…”

But the mummified corpse clearly was not listening. He kept howling like a ghost. The racket he made sounded as lively as a steam?engine core room. He rattled on about “resealing,” “give me a rope,” “hang me from the mast,” and other such nonsense, the very picture of torn reason and emotional corruption.

To be honest, after half a minute of this, Ted Riel actually started to miss his “lovely” students. Even though they often looked at him with clear but foolish eyes, the worst thing they ever did in class was fall asleep.

That was much quieter than this.

Luckily, the noisy mummified corpse did not keep it up for long. Just when Ted Riel was truly starting to think about taking Anomaly 077’s suggestion and beating him half to death, the cabin door opened.

Lawrence, still wrapped in faint green flames, pushed the door open and came in.

The anomaly who had been crying and wailing a moment before fell silent at once. He grinned and greeted the captain, then vanished from the room almost in the blink of an eye.

Ted Riel stared, stunned, in the direction the “sailor” had gone.

After a long moment, he finally turned his head toward Lawrence. “I never thought that the ‘sailor’ who struck fear into so many mariners would be like this after going into a runaway state…”

Lawrence looked surprised. “You’ve never met Miss Alice?”

“…All right, Captain, sir, you have a point,” Ted Riel said after thinking it over. He waved a hand. “Anything that gets mixed up with the Vanished seems to turn… unbelievable.”

“Yes, unbelievable, but at least not bad,” Lawrence said with a smile as he walked over. “Don’t mind that neurotic mummified corpse, and don’t take his talk about resealing too seriously. He’s just putting on a show. At first he really did try to run away from the Mortal Realm, but now he’s actually quite comfortable on this ship. He just refuses to admit it.”

“It sounds like you know Anomaly 077 very well.”

“A captain’s duty and basic skill,” Lawrence replied. “I have to know everyone on my ship. That fellow is included.” He sat down beside Ted Riel and glanced over his “temporary passenger’s” face. “How do you feel, Your Excellency Truth Keeper?”

“I can still hear faint noise in my head from time to time, but it’s much better than before,” Ted Riel said with a sigh. “The biggest problem now is the mess of memories crawling through my mind. So many scenes… real ones, fake ones, ones twisted by self?protection. It’s hard to tell which ones I can trust. I feel like I’ve been traveling through that dark place for a century… but you’re telling me I was only gone from Lightwind Harbor for a little more than ten minutes?”

“Yes, a little more than ten minutes, Your Excellency Truth Keeper,” Lawrence said with a nod. “When we fished you out, you had only been missing from the teleportation gate for a short while. So we very much want to know what exactly you went through in that ‘short while’.”

“‘We’?” Ted Riel had sharp ears. He did not miss that word.

“I just spoke with my boss. He already knows what happened here,” Lawrence said. “The Truth Keeper ‘vanishing’ has caused some chaos in Lightwind Harbor. Thankfully, the White Oak found you before that chaos could spread too far. As for the city, you don’t need to worry too much. While the Vanished is near that city, there is no place on the Boundless Sea safer than Lightwind Harbor. As for you…”

The old captain paused and thought for a moment before going on: “We still don’t know how much this last extinguishing of the Sun has changed the world. Trying to open a spatial passage again could be very dangerous. So you should stay on this ship for now and rest. While you have the time, tell me what you saw in that ‘darkness’. He is very interested in it.”

Ted Riel’s face slowly grew serious.

After a short silence, he looked into the old captain's eyes and said: "You should already know that my experience is tied to Subspace. That knowledge is not safe."

Lawrence shrugged. "My boss is tied to Subspace too. He is much less safe than your knowledge."

Ted Riel thought about it and had to admit the man was right.

"…All right. Where should I start?"

"Let's start with what you just mentioned while you were still half conscious," Lawrence said. "That inverted manor floating in the darkness…"

…

"Ted Riel is lucky, in a way. He survived Subspace, and he's recovering fairly well," Duncan said. "Right now he's on the White Oak, telling Lawrence about those unbelievable experiences. It may not be long before we receive some shocking information about Subspace."

Duncan ended his link with the White Oak for the moment and turned his attention back to Lightwind Harbor. He roughly explained the situation Lawrence had sent to him so far, then looked over at Lucretia.

"From what we know now, his experience was not the same as mine."

"…After all, he was only 'gone' for fifteen minutes, while you spent a century in Subspace," Lucretia said, her expression clearly complicated. "Just fifteen minutes was enough to tear at a Saint's sanity and almost turn him into a Subspace rift… and he was once able to hold out to the very end under Atlantis's influence…"

"Thankfully, the only loss on the White Oak's side was that Anomaly 077 took a punch," Duncan said, waving his hand. He quickly changed the

subject. “Before more news comes from over there, let’s focus on the world after the Sun went out… Lucy, I want to know what that strange ‘signal’ really was.”

Chapter 688: The Information in Alice’s Eyes

Lucretia brought over the copied paper tapes from the glowing orb Research Station, which recorded the latest “strange signal”. She also found the original signal that had first been recorded by the Radiant Star. Duncan stared at them for a few minutes and soon reached a conclusion—

He had no idea what this thing meant…

Drawing any conclusion from a pile of abstract signals was the job of real experts and scholars. And right now, even the real scholars were at a loss in front of these signals.

“They just look like tremors of random strength,” Morris stood under the lamp, spreading a long strip of paper on the table. He tried to find some pattern in the jumping curve as he frowned in thought. “We can convert each tremor’s amplitude into different numbers, or into ‘breaks’ of different lengths. But that just makes it some kind of cipher… Without the matching ‘codebook’, there’s no way to understand what these tremors mean.”

“From the first time we received these signals, the scholars have been trying to convert them into all kinds of forms,” Lucretia said at the side. “Including sound. After we transformed these tremors into electrical signals and fed them straight into playback devices, they sounded like some kind of continuous, low moaning or whispering. But there was no actual meaning in it. We also tried turning them into images, but that direction hasn’t made any progress yet.”

Duncan listened quietly, then suddenly spoke: “Could this be the ‘internal signal’ that the ‘glowing geometric body’ uses to communicate with the other structures of Vision 001?”

“We can’t rule that out,” Lucretia nodded. “The research station has a backup set of high-sensitivity recording equipment. Not long ago, that device also received a faint signal from the direction of Vision 001’s main structure. We have reason to believe that the ‘glowing geometric body’ still anchored off Lightwind Harbor is still in contact with Vision 001’s main structure…

“Both signals were related to the Sun going out,” Morris spoke again, lost in thought. “The first appeared after the Sun went out. The second appeared before the Sun went out. And the content of the signals was the same. To me, that feels… a lot like some kind of warning…”

Duncan said nothing. He walked to the window and looked outside in thought.

The whole city lay under a strange, cross-cut “twilight”.

The Sun in the sky had already gone out, but some kind of “suppressive” power from Vision 001 still seemed to be in effect. Because of that, the World’s Wound had not appeared with this early “veil of night”. At the moment, the sky was pure black, but at the same time, faint golden “sunlight” streamed in from the direction of the coast. It passed between the staggered high and low buildings, forming magnificent yet eerie bands of light over the streets.

The gas lamps along the streets and alleys had been lit early. There was not a single pedestrian on the roads. Only patrol squads of guardians and fast-moving steam walkers sometimes crossed the intersections, sweeping their lamps over the empty streets, full of vigilance and caution.

The city was very quiet. A heavy, tense mood filled the dimness, so much so that any sound from outside could tug at the nerves of those listening.

A soft rustling came from nearby. Alice had curiously picked up the tapes piled on the table. She turned them over and over, completely unable to make sense of them.

Shirley and Dog were lying at another window. Two heads leaned together as they looked out. Nina stood behind them, muttering about something under her breath.

“The situation in Pland and Frostholm is still fairly stable. Thanks to last time, people quickly restored order. But the Sun going out a second time is spreading unease through the cities,” Duncan said suddenly. “Aside from them, contact with the other city-states has been cut off again… just like before.”

“The only difference from last time is that we have four cathedral ships moored beside Lightwind Harbor this time,” Vanna said. “They were affected by the ‘glowing geometric body’ and stayed on this side after the Sun went out. Order on each cathedral ship has already been restored. Rune, Your Eminence seems to have activated some observation and research facilities on the Academy Ark. They’re collecting data on environmental changes in the Mortal Realm after the Sun went out…”

“I hope he finds something,” Duncan sighed. “But honestly, I don’t hold out much hope. Vision 001 has hung over this world for a full ten thousand years. I’m afraid only the ancient kingdom of Critt from back then, or the legendary Abyssal Lord who completed the Third Long Night, know what that thing really is…”

He had not finished when Alice’s voice suddenly came from the side: “Captain, captain! Captain, help! I’m stuck!”

Duncan turned his head and saw that Alice had already been wrapped up in a mass of paper tape around her head and arms. The silly doll stood in the middle of the pile, blinking innocently at them. She did not dare to move at all, as if she was afraid she might tear the fragile tapes if she struggled.

"…How did you even manage that?!" Duncan stared, shocked, then walked over, half angry and half amused, to free Alice from the paper entanglement. "You even got yourself wrapped up in this?"

"I don't know either!" Alice said in a very confident tone. "I just wanted to see how long this strip was. But I could never pull out the end. By the time I noticed, I was already stuck…"

Duncan let out a sigh: "Stop messing with them. These tapes are important."

"Oh…" Alice answered in a slightly dejected voice. She watched Duncan put the "paper strips" back into the box, looking just like a cat whose ball of yarn had been taken away. But soon she seemed to forget that small regret. Her expression turned bright again as she happily leaned toward Duncan. "Oh right, Captain, what is an 'Observer Effect stabilizer anchor'?"

Duncan, who had just picked up the ball of paper tape to put it away, froze on the spot.

The whole living room fell silent all at once.

This silly doll had just said a string of words that she clearly could not have "made up" on her own!

After two seconds of shock, Duncan slowly turned his head. His expression grew very serious: "What did you just… say?"

Alice jumped, thinking she had messed something up again. "Observation… Observer Effect stabilizer anchor… Did I say the wrong thing?"

“Why did you suddenly bring that up?” Duncan dropped the tapes in his hands and took two quick steps to stand in front of Alice. When he saw the tension on the doll’s face, he quickly softened his tone. “Don’t be afraid. You didn’t do anything wrong. But you just mentioned a very… unusual term.”

Alice stared at him with wide eyes. Under his gaze, she relaxed a little. Then she looked left and right, as if studying something others could not see, and said casually: “Observer Effect stabilizer anchor failure. Error code E-C6-305. ‘Star Coronet’ damaged. Main system restarting. Restart time unknown…”

Lucretia finally reacted. She rushed up to Alice and pointed at the tapes on the table: “You figured that out from these tapes?! Is that what they recorded?”

“No,” Alice shook her head innocently. “I don’t know what the messy curves on these strips mean. But there are failure warnings for the Observer Effect stabilizer anchor everywhere… Eh? You can’t see them?”

The doll seemed to realize something at last. She looked at the others with a surprised expression. That surprise and confusion… was just like when she had first learned that “ordinary people” could not see the drifting lines all around them.

Duncan stared at the doll and slowly realized something. He lifted his head and looked out the window at the weakened “sunlight” that slipped in past the shadows of the buildings.

These beams of “sunlight” came from the huge glowing geometric body out on the sea. After being blocked by layer upon layer of buildings and weakened by distance, they had grown very faint here.

But the information carried in the spectrum would not vanish because of that degree of weakening. It spread through the air. It filled the whole city.

In Alice's eyes, it was everywhere.

"So you can directly see the signals released by that 'glowing geometric body'," Duncan withdrew his gaze from the window and looked at Alice. "What… do they look like?"

"I can't really say," Alice scratched her hair. "And I don't even know if it counts as 'seeing'… I just feel there's something inside the light. Then the meaning appears straight in my head. Oh, although Goathead says I don't have a brain…"

Morris came over too. He stared at the doll in amazement. "Then why didn't you say so earlier?"

"You never asked!" Alice was even more confident this time. "And I thought you all could see it!"

Everyone in the room could not help but look at each other.

Clearly, each of them was thinking about those "lines" in Alice's eyes—the very same things the doll had once thought everyone could see.

But Duncan was thinking of even more.

He thought of the little sea bird with black feathers that Rune had brought to the assembly—the Mad Bird.

He also thought of the painting Alice had made, and of the "lines" she had insisted on adding to every person in it.

Alice seemed a bit uneasy. After speaking so boldly, she had finally noticed how different she was from the others. She thought she must have done something wrong. She edged closer to Duncan, hunching her shoulders. "I really didn't know at first…"

“Different observers see different worlds. For Alice, the world has looked different from ours right from the start. She took that for granted and never thought to ask everyone what the world looked like to them,” Duncan broke the silence. He turned and gently pressed his hand down on Alice’s hair. “Don’t be nervous. You didn’t do anything wrong. You did very well. Alice, you’ve done a great service. You’ve seen information that we can’t see…”

He softly rubbed the doll’s hair, helping her relax bit by bit. His gaze went past the window, as if it passed over the rows of buildings in the city and reached the Sun that still hung motionless over the sea.

Vision 001—Observer Effect stabilizer anchor.

Chapter 689: A Neglected “Connection”?

At Lightwind Harbor, faint “sunlight” spread from the surface of the sea and covered the whole city-state under the veil of night. The information carried by the light flowed silently through the sea. Yet there was only one doll who could read that information.

To be honest, even Duncan felt this was a bit unbelievable.

In this doll’s eyes, how many things in the world were different from common understanding? Was the sky blue in her view? Were the leaves green? What shape did humans have in her eyes, and what kind of waves did the sea carry?

And even if she described what she saw—were the colors, sounds, and shapes she spoke of really the same as what ordinary people understood?

This seemed like a puzzle that would always circle around itself and never be solved.

Alice turned her head. The glow of the gas lamp reflected in her large, pretty eyes. She looked at Duncan with a mix of doubt and worry. After a long time, she asked in a small voice: “Captain, the things I see really are useful, right?”

Duncan’s scattered thoughts slowly drew back. He did not let those messy ideas keep spreading. At that moment, he suddenly agreed with something

Alice had once said—some annoying questions that clearly have no answer are better left unasked.

So he smiled. His expression relaxed a little: “Of course they’re useful. Besides that information, what else did you see? I mean after the Sun went out. Did you ‘see’ anything that was different from usual?”

Alice quickly understood what he meant. She frowned slightly and tried hard to recall. Then she turned her head and looked around. After a while, she spoke, not very sure: “If I have to say something… I always feel there’s a buzzing sound…”

Duncan frowned: “Buzzing?”

“Yeah. Buzzing. It’s a very soft sound. And I can’t even say for sure that it’s really a ‘sound’,” Alice said, waving her hands as she explained. “I just feel like there’s something making noise in my head all the time. But if I don’t pay attention, I forget it. When I look at that ‘sunlight’, the sound gets a bit stronger…”

Duncan nodded lightly. After a moment, he asked again: “Last time the Sun went out, did you hear this buzzing sound? Did you see those ‘messages’ about the ‘Observer Effect stabilizer anchor’?”

“No,” Alice shook her head, holding her temples. “I only ‘saw’ and heard them this time, after we came to Lightwind Harbor…”

Listening to the doll’s story, Duncan sank into thought.

According to Lucretia, just now, another set of observation equipment in Lightwind Harbor had received faint signals from the extinguished Sun. Their features were exactly the same as the signals released by the glowing geometric body. In other words, during the blackout, the main body of Vision 001 had also been “broadcasting” a report of failure about the “Observer Effect stabilizer anchor”.

Yet Alice said that during the last blackout of the Sun, she had not “seen” this content. She had only read the failure report from the “sunlight” here after she arrived at Lightwind Harbor… Why?

Was it because the malfunction during the last blackout had not been this serious, so the main body of Vision 001 had not sent out a failure report?

If that was the explanation, then the situation was more serious than anyone had expected. That would mean the whole system had suffered further deterioration—and in such a short time.

The living room grew quiet. Lucretia, Morris, and the others had gathered around. They listened to the talk between Duncan and Alice and looked at the changing expression on Duncan’s face with some worry. After a while, Nina finally could not hold back: “Uncle Duncan, do you know what that ‘Observer Effect stabilizer anchor’ means?”

Duncan opened his mouth, but suddenly felt stuck.

In this world, explaining the ideas of planets and the universe was already extremely difficult. How was he supposed to explain the even more abstract “Observer Effect”? How could he explain the strange things that happen between the macroscopic and microscopic worlds?

And more importantly—could the Observer Theory he knew really be used here?

His expression grew complicated as he raised his head and looked out at the world beyond the window.

“I can guess a few things,” he said slowly. “But it’s very different from the ‘Observer Theory’ I know. It should have taken place in the microscopic world, not…”

He stopped, hesitating.

If Vision 001’s other name really was “Observer Effect stabilizer anchor”, then did that explain the true mechanism by which this ancient Vision “suppressed corruption” and “stabilized order”?

Without meaning to, he thought of the truth behind the Great Annihilation. He thought of the conflicts at the bottom of all things, and thought of the various extraordinary manifestations spreading across the whole world because of cognitive corruption. If the microscopic world was the “keystone of order” for each universe, then when those keystones collided and were wiped out, mixing into a vast, chaotic soup of information… would the Observer Effect still be limited to the microscopic world?

At the moment when the mathematical rules of each universe were torn apart, at the instant when the structure of all matter was completely destroyed and everything was reduced back to basic bits of information—perhaps the very ideas of “micro” and “macro” had already vanished!

In that storm-like rush of thoughts, Duncan murmured without meaning to: “…The corruption of information at the bottom of all things, and the clash of laws… might actually be the Observer Effect falling into a runaway state in the macroscopic world?”

Morris and Lucretia looked at each other. A few seconds later, they turned their heads at the same time. “…Huh?”

“…I’ll find a way to explain to you what the ‘Observer Effect’ is, and what I’m guessing about it, but that will take a lot of time and effort,” Duncan waved his hand quickly. “Right now I want to figure out another question.”

Lucretia spoke at once: “Another question?!”

Duncan nodded and looked at the brother-only doll standing beside him, her face pure and harmless—mostly because she still hadn’t caught up.

“Have you ever thought about this,” he asked, “why can Alice see and understand those ‘signals’?”

“Oh, right!” Shirley reacted at once—mainly because this was the only question so far that she fully understood. “It’s one thing for her to ‘see’ them. Those ‘lines’ can only be seen by her anyway. But how can she understand them? There are so many experts and scholars in the city. They’ve been tearing their hair out over this, and no one has figured it out!”

Vanna was sharp enough to notice the serious, thoughtful look on Duncan’s face when he raised the question. “You already have an answer, don’t you?”

Duncan slowly nodded. After a moment of thinking and choosing his words, he brought up what was written in The Blasphemous Tome:

“You should remember that according to that book, after two failed Genesis Protocols, it was the Crawling King who successfully completed the Genesis Protocol during the Third Long Night and opened the Deep Sea era.”

Vanna nodded at once: “Yes, of course we remember that.”

“The ‘construction’ of Vision 001 also happened in that same era,” Duncan went on seriously. “The Crawling King had the Critt clan serve as his assistants. Together they designed and built ‘the Sun’. And the Crawling King is the same being we know as the ‘Abyssal Lord’. Do you remember how Alice was born?”

“Oh, I know this one!” Shirley lit up at once. “The Abyssal Lord’s replicant pinched her together by hand on the seafloor!”

Everyone understood at once.

All their eyes turned to Alice.

Alice listened to everyone talking about her, and only now did she finally catch up. After she confirmed that she had not messed anything up, she did not know what she started thinking about, but her face showed a proud and happy expression.

"…We have always known that, in a sense, Alice is a 'creation of the Abyssal Deep'," Duncan said. He looked at the doll, who had somehow grown proud, and thought of that time in the garden of the manor when he had accidentally made contact with the Abyssal Lord. "But most of the time, we only focused on her connection with Queen Ray Nora of Frostholm and ignored that her link with the Abyssal Lord is the real key.

"Now it seems that connection may be more important than we thought. At least one thing is clear. She can understand the 'system language' the Abyssal Lord used in that 'creation blueprint'…"

Nina thought for a moment. "Like how a punch-card analyzer can read the paper tape output from a Sorting Engine?"

"…That's a fine way to think about it."

Alice looked at Duncan, then at the others. She seemed to want to ask something, but suddenly she frowned, as if she had heard or seen something. A moment later, she said: "The system has restarted."

Duncan instantly lifted his head. Almost at the same time, a low, unreal rumbling sounded in everyone's mind.

With that deep roar that seemed to fill the whole world in an instant, Duncan saw a streak of glow appear in the sky outside the window—

The Sun, which had sunk down near the horizon and gone dark and still, lit up once more.

Shirley was the first to rush to the window. She pressed her head to the glass and looked down at the street. She saw the glow spill over the roofs,

and a squad of Knowledge Guards standing watch at the corner, all raising their heads in surprise to look at the sky.

Nearby, some residents who had been hiding at home reacted as well. They opened their windows and peered outside.

Shirley happily waved from the window toward a neighbor who had appeared at another window not far away, but no one answered her—everyone's attention was fixed on the glow that had returned to the sky.

Soon, faint cheers drifted in from somewhere far away. After a while, the loudspeaker at the intersection crackled to life.

The broadcast announced that the Sun had lit up again. It also reminded the residents not to rush out of their homes. The veil of night would fall soon, and the curfew would remain in force through the night until the Sun rose again as usual the next day.

Duncan listened to the faint broadcast from outside and watched the glow slowly fade from the sky. He let out a slow breath.

The Sun rising as usual… Now, even that had become something uncertain.

Chapter 690

This time, the Sun went out when it was close to dusk, so not long after the sky lit up again, the sunlight slowly faded away from the surface of the sea.

Vision 001’s magnificent double rune rings slowly sank into the ocean. As the last streak of afterglow vanished from the sky, the veil of night descended. In the districts that the glowing geometric body could not shine on directly, the cold radiance from the World’s Wound and the darkness of night covered everything as usual.

The city grew quiet. The gas lamps on the streets gave off a slightly murky glow under the veil of night. Patrol squads of guardians walked through the streets and alleys, their figures stretching into long shadows at each intersection. The Sun going out felt like a dream that was not quite real, and it was slowly melting into the night.

But Duncan could feel that this “nightmare” had not really faded the way it seemed on the surface. A heavy air still lingered over the city. In these silent neighborhoods, tension and unease grew in the veil of night like thick, sticky sludge.

“Every household has turned on all their lights. The air is tense everywhere,” Shirley lay at the living room window, muttering as she watched the street outside. “I definitely don’t want to go out on the street right now… I feel like I can’t even breathe.”

Dog beside her shook his head and wobbled his neck: “There are at least twice as many guards outside today. If you go out on the street now, the

night watch guards will pin you down the moment they see you. You still want to breathe? Then the Captain will have to go to the station and fish us out again. At that point you really won't be able to breathe…"

Vanna leaned against the window. She lowered her head and glanced at Shirley, who was sprawled on the sill: "I didn't expect you to be so sensitive to 'atmosphere'."

"I know this feeling very well. The gas lamps in the Lower City always lit up later than in other districts. When the veil of night was about to fall, many people couldn't afford electric lights at home. That tense mood would show up as the sky grew darker. Only when the gas lamps lit up would the whole street let out a long breath, like 'whooosh'. Then we knew we could sleep in peace."

"But tonight, even with the whole city lit up, a lot of people are destined to stay awake," Duncan walked over. He pressed one hand lightly on Shirley's hair and used the other to rub Dog's head. "After the Sun has gone out a second time, even the most optimistic people can't help worrying about one thing – whether the Sun will still rise tomorrow."

Shirley tilted her head to the side. Then she suddenly jerked up and stared at Duncan in horror: "…Huh!? It really won't rise tomorrow?!"

Duncan's face looked odd: "…How would I know? It's not up to me."

"Oh." Shirley scratched her hair. "That's true…"

At that moment Lucretia walked over from the side: "There's news from the Observatory. The signal released by the glowing orb has completely stopped. They're getting ready to send a small team into the glowing orb to check whether that 'stone sphere' has changed."

Duncan raised his eyebrows: "Night work?"

“For the sea where the glowing geometric body is, it is always daytime,” Lucretia spread her hands. “sunlight can calm the power of anomalies on the Boundless Sea. Research around the glowing geometric body has always run in shifts, twenty-four hours a day.”

Duncan nodded. Then he suddenly turned his head in thought and looked toward Alice, who was not far away helping Lunie wind her spring.

The doll noticed his gaze. She raised her head and gave him a harmless, bright smile.

After the Sun lit up again, the error-report signals in Alice’s “eyes” had disappeared. She had gone back to her daily self as if nothing had happened.

But now Duncan felt curious. If he brought her to that stone sphere at this moment, what would happen? This doll, who was in theory a “creation” of the Abyssal Deep Patron, might see something in front of a fragment of Vision 001, which was also made by the Abyssal Deep Patron, that an ordinary person could not see.

In fact, Duncan had once taken Alice to see the glowing geometric body before. But back then, no one realized she and Vision 001 actually shared an almost “same source” connection, so he had not tested anything in that direction. Alice herself had not paid special attention to the glowing geometric body either.

This time, he wanted to run a more deliberate “test”.

“Lucy, I need you to arrange something for me,” Duncan turned his head to Lucretia. “I want to take Alice to see that stone sphere.”

Lucretia froze for a moment, but she quickly understood what Duncan meant and nodded at once: “Understood.”

Duncan grunted in reply, then looked to his side at the empty air.

A streak of ghost-green flame rose out of nowhere where his gaze fell, and a fat pigeon burning with spirit flame flapped its wings and appeared in front of him: “teleportation successful! teleportation successful!”

“We should bring that unlucky ‘Truth Keeper’ over as well,” Duncan said casually. “Go to Lawrence. The White Oak can serve as your beacon. You know the way, right?”

AI tilted his head. After thinking for a moment, he flapped his wings hard: “Air wife! Imaginary wife! Air wife! Imaginary wife!”

“…Lawrence’s wife isn’t imaginary anymore. Don’t say that in front of Martha. She’ll stew you,” Duncan’s eye twitched as he glared at the pigeon, who seemed to get fatter by the day. “On second thought, you can leave a bit later. After that, send Ted Riel straight to the stone sphere. I happen to want to talk to him.”

The pigeon became excited again: “Talk therapy, also known as talk cure~~”

Duncan: “…”

…

Ted Riel wore a warm, thick coat and slowly walked along the stern deck. The cold night wind blew from the sea, carrying a salty, fishy smell. The soft waves tapped against the hull again and again. In the darkness, the sound rose and fell, and his mood gradually calmed.

After the Sun lit up again, it set normally. Familiar dusk passed, and then the quiet veil of night arrived. At this moment, even the cold light of the World’s Wound felt a bit gentle.

“As someone who just finished doing the butterfly stroke in Subspace, your recovery isn’t bad.”

A hoarse, unpleasant voice came from the deck not far away. Ted followed the sound and saw a hideous mummified corpse in a sailor's smock sitting on a coil of rope near the rail, smiling at him in the dark.

That smile was enough to give a person nightmares for a whole night.

Ted frowned and walked toward the mummified corpse. He leaned on the railing beside it.

"You don't actually need that thick coat, Mr. Truth Keeper," the "Sailor" glanced at the coat on Ted's shoulders and spoke casually. "As far as I know, the Saints are built differently from normal people. A little soak in seawater shouldn't be enough to make you feel cold… Or is the chill of Subspace still soaking into you?"

"…This is Captain Lawrence's kindness," Ted looked down at the coat on himself and answered. Then he frowned again. "I feel like… you know a lot about Saints."

"I know a little," the Sailor bared his teeth in a rough grin. "I know that whatever you used to be, after you receive divine blessings, you can't be counted as completely 'alive' anymore. I know your skin can block blades. Your bones can shatter and then grow back. Even if your heart breaks apart, your blood still flows. You can survive for days without breathing. Even a 'scholar' like you, once promoted, fears neither heat nor cold, nor diseases, nor most poisons…"

He paused, then casually took a bottle of beer from beside him. As he swung it lightly, he kept speaking: "Strictly speaking, you Saints are a group of anomalies kept in an unsealed state. Ordinary anomalies go into runaway state once they are unsealed, but you… those divine blessings that were given to you are still controlling you."

Listening to the mummified corpse ramble, Ted's expression suddenly grew serious: "How do you know all this?"

"I'm a Sailor. Sailors should know many strange things, because we are the restless souls wandering on the Boundless Sea," the Sailor stretched his cracked lips in another grin and raised the beer in his hand. "We wander when we're alive, or wander after we're dead. Wander long enough, and you learn things. There is nothing new on the Boundless Sea. Want a drink? Pure Storm Brew. Good wine made by the Deep Sea Church. I stole it from the captain's private stash."

"…You dared to steal from the captain?"

"Stealing wine from the captain's stash is also a necessary part of being a Sailor. Getting hanged from the mast afterward is another part," the mummified corpse laughed in his hoarse voice. He raised the bottle and poured it straight down his throat. A moment later, the beer leaked out through the holes in his ruined chest and a large tear at the side of his neck, dripping onto the deck. "Ahhh… good stuff."

Ted did not care about the mummified corpse's jokes. He still watched this anomaly number 077 with suspicion. In official records, it was marked as a "special runaway-state anomaly". After a while, he suddenly asked, "You must have been a person once, right?"

"How would I know?" the Sailor shrugged without concern. "Under certain conditions, 'people' can become anomalies too. If you think I was, then sure, I was."

Ted noticed that the Sailor was dodging the question, so he did not push further. After a few seconds of silence, he suddenly changed the subject: "Where is this ship going?"

“Lunsa. The captain took a big job. We’re going there to pick up twelve sealed objects and transport them to another northern city-state.”

“…How many?!”

“Twelve.”

“…A large transport ship personally escorted by a Saint is only supposed to carry eight anomalies at a time. Have you never considered the strict containment rules for anomalies, or the possibility that they might conflict and interfere with one another?” Ted stared in shock. “Who signed the permit for you?!”

“The Deep Sea Church did. Why?” The Sailor gave Ted a glance. “Don’t make such a fuss. This is the Vanished Fleet’s dedicated transport service. We’re carrying twelve because Lunsa only has twelve sealed objects that meet the shipping conditions. As for sealed objects going into runaway state…”

The mummified corpse stopped, then raised a hand and pointed at himself. “I’m the only runaway-state anomaly on this ship. I’m on duty here twenty-four hours a day. Go ashore and I fight. Back on board I scrub the deck. When someone finishes doing the butterfly stroke in Subspace, I have to dive down and fish him out. If I had a second chance, I’d rather rot in the shroud and never wake up.

“Any anomaly that needs ‘transfer transport’ to strengthen its seal has at least some thinking ability. When they see me like this, every single one of them gets quiet as a quail once they’re on board. The ones that can move on their own even learned to help close the sealed vault door after the captain finishes his inspection…”

Ted: “…?”

Chapter 691

Ted followed the movement and sat down beside anomaly 077.

“Really not going to have some?” anomaly 077 grinned and shook the beer bottle again, then pointed at a corner nearby. “I’ve got another bottle there. This kind of internal-only good stuff is hard to find again once you miss it. As far as I know, Lightwind Harbor doesn’t have this. Try it. If you’re still soaked in the chill of Subspace, the alcohol might help.”

“Since you know so much about Saints, you should know alcohol does nothing for me,” Ted gave the mummified corpse a glance, then turned his eyes away and shook his head. “There’s something I’m very curious about.”

Anomaly 077 shrugged: “Ask. I might not answer.”

“…How does an ‘anomaly’ like you, one with a complete mind, see this world?” Ted asked very seriously. Then, maybe thinking the question sounded a bit abrupt, he thought for a moment and added, “I’ve dealt with many people and read many wise thinkers’ writings about the world. I understand the mortal point of view. But when I look at you, I suddenly want to know how a rational anomaly like you sees the world…”

“Ah, such a philosophical question right away. As expected of a Truth Keeper,” anomaly 077 clicked his tongue. “But haven’t you met Miss Alice? Why didn’t you ask her?”

Ted went quiet for a moment: “…I feel she has no opinion about the world.”

“…Ah, then it seems you really did meet Miss Alice,” the Sailor laughed happily and took another gulp of beer. While the liquid trickled down onto the deck, he leaned his head back. “You’re asking for my opinion? I think this world might as well be destroyed.”

Ted frowned without thinking.

“That’s your question, Mr. Truth Keeper,” the Sailor said. Noticing the change in Ted’s expression, he glanced over, then turned his eyes back to the sky. “And don’t you think so? The Sun has already gone out twice. City-state-level disasters keep happening. Blasphemous and banished things keep waking and returning.

“In my eyes, this world is full of cracks, shadows, hollows, and a kind of noise like something dying… You people, noble and stubborn – I’m not being sarcastic – you spend your days thinking about nothing but patching this world back together. But use that scholar’s mind of yours and think it through… can it still be fixed?”

Ted frowned but did not answer. He had not expected such an answer from a question asked out of casual curiosity. The attitude of the Sailor surprised him even more. These answers were not coming off the top of his head. They sounded like conclusions he had reached after watching and thinking about the world for a very long time.

Anomaly 077 did not care about Ted’s silence.

“This world is finished, Mr. Truth Keeper. As a Sailor, I can smell a coming storm better than you. Compared to a few hundred years ago, now the world is riddled with cracks. It’s like an old house that has broken open in countless places. At the next widening of those holes, the howling wind will destroy this already-crumbling place.

“All your patching means nothing. Once the keystone collapses, painting the walls or pasting newspapers over the holes only gives the people inside a brief, fake sense of peace.

“Now listen, Mr. Truth Keeper. Raise your ears and really listen…”

The Sailor leaned closer. Right in front of Ted, he put a hand next to his own ear in a listening pose, a half-smile on his face.

“Do you hear it? That hollow, sharp noise… That is the wind blowing from Subspace… It passes through all those gaps big and small and vibrates in a range ordinary people cannot hear. I’ve always heard it.

“Now, you can too.”

A faint noise echoed all around, yet it also seemed to ring directly in his head. It was low and weak, but impossible to ignore.

Ted’s eyes opened a little wider. He stared at the Sailor with a heavy, pressuring gaze.

“Relax, Mr. Truth Keeper. This is how it is when you deal with Subspace. Once you get a little on you, it sticks for life,” the Sailor did not seem bothered at all by the look Ted gave him. He shifted to a more comfortable position and slouched deeper into the pile of rope. “You somehow managed to escape from that place, and I won’t bother guessing what kind of ‘sacred miracle’ kept you alive. But clearly, Subspace still left a tiny mark on you.

“Compared to all those poor souls who went mad and turned into monsters after one accidental glimpse of Subspace, this little side effect is already very lucky.”

“…This is also something a Sailor is supposed to understand?”

“Of course.” The mummified corpse nodded as if it were obvious, not caring whether anyone believed him.

Ted: “…”

The Sailor did not care what Ted thought. The frightening mummified corpse only shifted again, sinking even more lazily into the ropes. He shook the bottle in his hand and muttered, “Try to see it this way. The world is just like this. Whether you take it hard or take it easy, you still have to live the day. If you have wine in your hand, you should drink it while you can. If you can drift one more day, then drift one more day.

“I can’t go back to sleep now. If I could, I’d definitely sleep straight until Doomsday. But things are pretty good as they are. I’ll just keep my eyes open and wait for the world’s Doomsday to arrive…”

At this point, the Sailor turned his head a little and gave Ted a half-smile.

“As for you, Mr. Truth Keeper, you still have your own work to do. Now it’s time to go back – back to your post, to keep patching this shaky wreck of a house.

“Even if it doesn’t help, maybe… this world keeps moving forward day after day exactly because of this ‘useless’ holding on. Maybe one day, at the end of all that emptiness, a road suddenly appears. When that happens, every bit of clinging on will have meaning.”

The low, chaotic noise spread through Ted’s mind again. The aftereffects from Subspace made him feel dazed. He felt that something was wrong with his senses, but before he could figure out what, a crackling sound suddenly came from the nearby deck and broke his thoughts.

He followed the sound and saw ghost-green flames rising on the planks. The fire flared up at once and twisted into a rotating doorway of flame, and a skeletal roc wreathed in fire charged out, circling above his head.

Ted froze for a second and had just opened his mouth to speak when his vision blurred. The burning monster bird wrapped around him and dragged

him straight into the doorway.

The flaming door went out with a boom. The deck fell quiet again, as if everything just now had been an illusion.

The Sailor leaned in the pile of ropes, holding his bottle and staring blankly. Not far from him, a writhing shadow suddenly appeared in the air.

The shadow quickly grew solid and clear, gaining shape and color. In almost an instant, it became an old man in a worn white robe, his face covered in deep wrinkles.

The old man was thin and slightly hunched, like a traveler who had walked through countless years on a long road. He stood in the pale light of the World's Wound. The hazy shadows at his feet stretched forward, covering anomaly 077's body.

After a brief silence, the old man in the ragged robe turned his head. His gaze was deep as he looked toward the direction where Ted had vanished. He muttered softly, "…Emptiness…"

In the next second, his figure simply vanished into the wind, like a wrong fragment of time that had left a ghostly image a moment ago and then disappeared without a trace.

The Sailor shivered, then lifted his head in confusion. He sat up from the pile of rope and, out of habit, raised the bottle to his mouth for another drink. A moment later he frowned. "Why doesn't this water have any taste…"

Then his eyes finally fell on the bottle in his hand.

"…What the hell!!!"

…

The gray-white stone sphere, its surface covered in crater-like rings, hung quietly above the sea. A small research platform at the “waist” of the stone sphere bathed in soft golden sunlight. Several scholars in short research robes stood tense at the edge of the platform, uneasy and nervous as they watched the figure at the front.

Alice stood there, craning her neck as she leaned close to the stone sphere to study the strange giant object.

Duncan grabbed her head and pushed it back onto her neck: “Quit fooling around – you’ll fall into the sea!”

“Oh, oh…” Alice shrank her neck at once. She held her head in place with both hands and blinked at the stone sphere in front of her. After staring for a long time, she finally said, “I still can’t see anything…”

“After you got close to the stone sphere, you didn’t hear or see any ‘extra information’?” Duncan frowned at the doll. “What about the sunlight around it? After entering the inside of this glowing orb, did you hear or see anything?”

Alice narrowed her eyes and looked around at the golden light floating on the sea, which was like some crystal veil. The glow reflected in her pretty purple eyes and rippled like water.

She stared around like this for quite a while, then turned to Duncan and said, “…No information.”

Duncan looked a bit disappointed: “No information?”

Alice nodded, then carefully checked again what appeared “in front of her eyes” when her divine gaze fell on the golden light. She nodded once more. “Yes, it’s all showing ‘No information’.”

Duncan: “…”

He suddenly realized that when talking to this silly doll, it was necessary to ask one or two follow-up questions. Who could guess the way this doll's mind worked?!

He had just opened his mouth to keep questioning her when a crackling sound from the air nearby cut him off.

ghostly green flames rose, and a whirling doorway of fire opened in midair.

"AI is back with our guest," Duncan waved at Alice and turned to face the doorway. But an instant later, his expression shifted. "Wait, the door is off–"

Before he could finish, the fiery door burst open. A familiar figure fell out of it, skimming the edge of the platform and dropping straight into the sea below.

Ted Riel's short shout came from the middle of it.

The skeletal roc, cloaked in flame, flew out right after. It circled proudly twice in the air, then landed on the platform, stretched its neck to look down, and let out a sharp cry: "See? I can fly!"

Duncan stared, dumbfounded. Alice crept carefully to the edge of the platform and peeked down, then patted her chest in fright. "He really did fall into the sea…"

Duncan slowly turned his head and looked at AI. Then he shifted his gaze toward where Ted had fallen.

…What had that unlucky Truth Keeper done to offend this pigeon?

Chapter 692: Everything the Truth Keeper Saw

Ted Riel wrapped himself in a thick blanket and sat in the small cabin at the research station. Someone handed him a cup of hot tea that was still almost too hot to hold. He cupped it in both hands, looked up, and said: “Thank you.”

“You’re welcome!” Alice answered very seriously, then began to curiously study this Truth Keeper who had just been pulled out of the sea. After quite a while, she turned her head toward Duncan and said: “Captain, Mr. Ted doesn’t look like he’s in a very good mood!”

“I fell into the sea – twice!” Ted lifted his head to look at Duncan standing to the side. Halfway through speaking, he shivered without thinking. The physical cold did not matter to a Saint; that shiver felt more like he had been soaked in the chill of fate itself. “The first time I fell out of Subspace. The second time, a pigeon threw me out!”

He shivered again, then turned and glared with deep resentment at the fat White Dove strutting across the floor with its chest puffed out. The bird scraped its beak on the floor, tilted its head so that one eye looked out the window and the other fixed on Ted, then flapped its wings: “What are you staring at?”

“You must have offended AI,” Duncan’s calm voice came from the side. “It usually doesn’t throw passengers into the sea.”

“Is it impossible that you’re just a cruel pigeon by nature?” Ted glared, looking very upset. “When it threw me down, it even mocked me. Everyone here heard it…”

“That’s impossible. AI is a peace dove,” Duncan quickly waved his hand and pointed at AI wandering around. “Look, it’s white.”

Ted stared, unable to follow Duncan’s line at all. He had never even heard what a peace dove was.

However, Duncan was already used to no one getting the jokes he blurted out. He just waved it off carelessly: “I guess you didn’t cooperate much when AI brought you here.”

“…Fine, I admit it,” Ted thought for a moment and sighed helplessly. “But you can’t blame me. I don’t even know this pigeon of yours. Even if that flame looked familiar, when a skeletal monster bird suddenly flew out and swept me into a dark and strange space, of course my first reaction was to feel threatened. It was inevitable that I would fight back a little…”

Lucretia, who had stayed quiet at the side, suddenly cut in: “And then you lost to the pigeon and got thrown into the sea.”

Ted Riel said: “…Can we stop talking about the pigeon?”

“Fair point,” Duncan nodded and sat down on the chair next to Ted. “Then we’ll end the pigeon topic here. Next, let’s talk about Subspace.”

“Uh…” Ted grumbled in his throat, his face turning very odd. But the string of unbelievable events had clearly toughened his nerves. He quickly let out a resigned, calm breath and looked around.

The academy staff stationed here slipped out of the room almost in a flash and closed the door. In a few seconds, only Duncan, Alice, and Lucretia were left with him.

“I’ve already told Captain Lawrence everything I could remember,” Ted breathed out a little once the unrelated people were gone. He spoke while he tried to recall: “Subspace left a long-lasting chaos of shadows in my mind. Some of my memories became blurry. I can only remember scattered fragments that don’t connect, like those silent, huge, and strange ‘things’ I saw. You should already know that part…”

“Yes. Lawrence reported the situation to me, but some things have to be talked through face to face to be clear,” Duncan said casually. “For example, the exact shapes of those things you saw. Lawrence’s retelling just can’t compare to hearing it from you directly…”

As he spoke, he casually pulled a drawing from the table beside him.

Those were some sketches Duncan had drawn himself after receiving Lawrence’s report and before AI brought Ted back.

Ted took the sheet Duncan handed him with curiosity. The moment he saw what was drawn on it, his eyes opened a little wider.

The drawing did not show anything horrifying or bizarre. It was only the outlines of doors and windows, some pillars with elegant, complex lines, and some curved ironwork patterns.

However, the “style” and “feeling” they gave off, to Ted, were no less shocking than seeing those gigantic horrors in Subspace again.

He hesitated and looked up. Duncan was calmly watching him, fixing him with that almost divine gaze.

“Is it this style?” Duncan asked softly.

Ted opened his mouth, then lowered his head again and stared hard at the partial building structures on the paper. After a long time, he spoke in a low voice: “Yes. It was a huge building in the dark. It looked like a palace, or maybe a mansion made too vast and complex. It hung upside down above

my head. Its spires made me think of those gloomy black towers in the northern city-states. Its doors and windows were long and tall. Outside every window, some dark material like thorns covered and blocked it…”

He stopped, thought for a moment, then continued: “The whole building stayed silent in the darkness, like a giant beast that had been dead for many years. But at some moments, I saw faint flashes in some of its windows, as if someone was still moving around inside it. At those times, the whole building felt as if it was about to come back to life…”

Duncan listened quietly to Ted’s description. His expression grew serious as he looked at the windows, pillars, and decorative patterns he had drawn on the paper.

Those were the things in Alice’s mansion. Although Ted had only seen the outside structure of the building, the style was clearly the same.

What Ted had seen was indeed Alice’s mansion.

Alice’s mansion that lay in Subspace.

But Duncan clearly remembered that after the “Mistress’s bedroom” in the depths of Alice’s mansion had been “taken away” by Ray Nora, a huge hollow was left there. When he looked outward from that hollow, he could only see endless darkness. He did not see the signature chaotic light currents and the huge entity shadows of Subspace. Otherwise, he would have realized long ago that the mansion was in Subspace.

Why was that?

Was it because what Ted saw in Subspace was only a “projection” of Alice’s mansion? Or was it that, when Duncan had looked out from the Great Hollow inside the mansion last time, something had “blocked” his sight?

Duncan frowned and sank into a long silence. After holding back for several minutes, Ted finally could not stand it and asked: “What exactly did I see?

You seem very familiar with it."

"Very familiar. I go there often," Duncan nodded lightly. "But don't ask about the details. It's for your mental and physical health."

"…All right. It is Subspace after all," Ted reacted at once. Then his expression turned strange again. "Rahm bless me, I never thought I would actually be talking with you about Subspace. I went there and came back alive. Even now it still doesn't feel real."

"It's a bit late to start feeling emotional about that now," Duncan waved his hand. Then he went on: "You also mentioned that the huge upside-down mansion changed before your eyes and turned into something like a giant ship?"

"In fact… I'm not even sure what that thing really was," Ted hesitated, then chose his words carefully. "Being in Subspace felt like moving through layers and layers of illusions. My reason and my understanding seemed split into two dimensions, working on their own. I saw many things, and they often turned into something else in an instant. Only some of those changes actually happened. The others felt like my own mind was rearranging information it couldn't understand."

Duncan thought for a moment, then pushed another blank sheet of paper and a pencil in front of Ted: "Whether it was an illusion or not, can you still draw how the mansion looked at the moment it changed?"

Ted hesitated, then took the paper and pencil: "…I can try."

This Truth Keeper wrapped the blanket around himself and went to the table. He bent over and began to sketch the hazy visions he had seen in Subspace.

Duncan stood to the side, watching with a serious and patient expression.

Under Ted's hand, messy and abstract lines slowly appeared on the paper.

However, Lucretia, who was watching curiously, slowly frowned: “This is the ‘giant ship’ you mentioned?”

She saw only many lines randomly linked together, like “fragments” of some abstract geometric body, pieced into a rough spindle shape or some uneven “cylinder”. It was very different from any “ship” she knew.

But the next second, she noticed Duncan’s expression growing more and more serious as he looked at those “abstract patterns”.

Father had seen something in those strange abstract lines!

He had seen this thing before?!

Questions flashed through Lucretia’s mind, but before she could ask, Ted had already put down the pencil.

“I know this doesn’t look like a ‘ship’, but the moment I saw it, my mind just felt that it had to be some kind of ‘ship’,” Ted looked up at Lucretia. “I can’t explain it. It was like some kind of ‘knowledge’ was stamped straight into my thoughts, or some kind of ‘revelation’…”

But Duncan kept staring hard at the messy lines Ted had drawn. Then he suddenly looked up and asked: “…Is it finished?”

Ted nodded: “It’s finished.”

Duncan frowned, his face strangely serious: “Is this all? Only this part?”

Ted finally sensed something from Duncan’s attitude. He hesitated: “This was all I saw… only this part. Is something wrong?”

Duncan stayed silent for a few seconds, then stepped forward and pointed at the drawing: “I’m not sure… but in theory, what you’ve drawn might be only one third of its full structure!”

Chapter 693: Shadows Noticed Afterward

“One third of the structure?”

Ted froze when he heard Duncan’s words. He looked in confusion at the messy, abstract lines he had drawn. To be honest, he thought his drawing was terrible, but it was already the closest he could get to his “original impression”. The lingering influence of Subspace had been disturbing his mind for a long time, so he still could not clearly recall the details of those memories. Even he could barely piece a complete image out of these broken lines.

Yet from Duncan’s tone, he realized that this ghost captain had not only recognized what was on the paper. Duncan even knew what the thing was supposed to look like.

Duncan stood at the table, frowning as he studied the details Ted had drawn. After a while, he pointed at a spot on the drawing: “Is the structure broken here?”

Ted frowned and forced himself to remember. At last a vague image rose in his mind: “I think so… but I’m not sure. I only glanced at it in a rush. I didn’t even have time to see the full side of the structure…”

“It breaks here, then extends outward. These are some connecting structures,” Duncan said, not minding the doubt in Ted’s voice. He picked up the pencil and quickly drew lines in the blank space of the paper. Under his hand, a strange thing with a three-part symmetrical body took shape. To

Ted and Lucretia, it looked nothing like any ‘ship’ at all. “It is made of three main structures like this… Here is where the engine group sits…”

Without realizing it, Lucretia had leaned close to the strange “drawing”. She stared at it for a full half minute before she finally could not hold back: “What… is this exactly?”

Duncan did not raise his head. After a few seconds of silence, he answered softly: “It is called the New Hope.”

Lucretia and Ted exchanged looks, then spoke in unison: “The New Hope?”

Alice also came over, a beat late, and asked: “What is the New Hope?”

Duncan lifted his head. His complicated, strange gaze fell on this brother doll, but she did not seem to notice at all. She only tilted her head: “Why are you looking at me?”

“…It was a ship. A starship,” Duncan took back his gaze and spoke in a low voice, his tone so subtle he himself was not sure what he felt. “Many, many years ago, it reached this world. Or rather, like the other ‘fragments’, it crashed into this heap of World Wreckage we live in.”

“A starship? A ship that flies?” Ted sounded shocked, then he reacted: “You mean another ‘world fragment’? A flying ship called the New Hope, and part of its wreckage fell into Subspace and turned into the mansion I saw…?”

He raised his hand and made a vague shape in the air, his face full of disbelief.

But Duncan did not answer the Truth Keeper’s question. He only lowered his head again and stared at the drawing on the table for a long time. On top of Ted’s sketch, his simple lines had outlined a rough picture of a great starship. It was far from a full copy, but it was clearly the same New Hope

he had once seen in a vision, dragging a long trail of fire as it fell into this world.

He still remembered how he had seen that vision in the first place.

It had been when he checked Alice's wind-up key. He had spread his own flames into the brass key. Just like every time he used this method to probe an extraordinary item, he had seen the "echo" left inside that wind-up key.

In that "echo", Alice's wind-up key had turned into some strange kind of data storage medium, and the New Hope had crashed in the final scene of the vision.

For a long time, he had been looking for clues about that starship. He had searched for any legends or records in this world that might be linked to some ancient crash. At the same time, he often wondered about one question.

Why would the vision of the New Hope's crash be recorded inside Alice's wind-up key?

What connection could this harmless brother doll have with a starship that had already crashed in the Age of Antiquity?

The gap between a "doll" and a "starship" was so huge that even Duncan's imagination could not link them. Yet now, an even more unbelievable clue had appeared before him.

Ted had seen Alice's mansion in Subspace. At certain moments, that mansion had taken on the shape of one third of the New Hope's wreckage!

Duncan had questioned Ted's memory and description at first, but he quickly ruled that out. Ted could not describe something he had never seen out of nowhere. Even if his memory was mixed up, he could not "happen" to sketch the New Hope's ship structure in that confusion.

Some scattered and broken clues seemed to be quietly linking together. Some wild guesses rose in Duncan's mind.

As his thoughts surged, Duncan reached into the inner pocket of his coat and felt out the brass key he used to wind Alice.

The brass key lay quietly in his palm. The cold metal end of the key took the classic "?" shape, as if it hid all its secrets inside endless silence.

After a moment, he put the key away. When he looked up, he met Lucretia's and Ted's curious yet hesitant gazes.

"Let's talk about something else first," Duncan shook his head and looked at Ted. "What else did you see in Subspace?"

Ted nodded. He realized that the New Hope might point to some secret that was too ancient and dangerous, so he wisely held back his curiosity. Instead, he went on describing the unbelievable sights he had seen in Subspace.

There were giant things standing on barren plains, a throne and a huge headless figure, an unnamed warrior who had died leaning against wreckage, and many other strange sights. He could not tell which of them were real and which came from his own mind.

Duncan did not interrupt again. He listened with full attention, nodding from time to time. Only when Ted finally finished did he let out a long breath.

The headless corpse on the throne, the unknown warrior beside strange wreckage, the huge structure on the wasteland… All of these were indeed bizarre. But in Subspace, anything might appear. At least in Duncan's eyes, all of these were easier to accept than "Alice's mansion exists in Subspace" and "Alice's mansion is part of the New Hope".

“…That was quite a journey. It’s hard to forget,” Lucretia said at last, breaking the quiet after listening quietly for a long time. “Fifteen minutes… Mr. Ted, those fifteen minutes of yours are enough for many scholars to study for a lifetime.”

“I could use those fifteen minutes to write academic papers for the rest of my life, but to be honest, I would rather never have had that experience,” Ted sighed. “You know, even now I can still sometimes hear that buzzing noise in my head. It moves around inside my awareness like a living thing. Even though I’ve had strict training in resilient psychology and Will-Control Theory, it is still unusually hard to resist this noise. And this aftereffect may last for a long time…”

He shrugged as he said this, his face looking a little bad.

“And what’s worse is that I have to go back to the academy tomorrow and face those stubborn students. Their clear yet foolish views on academic matters are like another kind of ‘Subspace noise’ to me…”

The Truth Keeper murmured this and raised his hand to press his forehead in pain. The lingering echo of Subspace and the foreseeable shadows of the future were clearly mixing together, casting a deep shadow in his heart.

Seeing this, Duncan had no idea how to comfort him. He could only sigh softly and pat Ted on the shoulder: “I understand that feeling very well.”

Ted was a little surprised. He looked up at Duncan in confusion: “How would you understand?”

Duncan paused for a moment. It felt hard to explain, but soon Shirley’s homework notebook and Alice’s doodle book floated up in his mind.

“…On my ship there are people who are even ‘clearer’ than your students.”

Ted stared blankly for a moment. He did not know how much he understood, but he still nodded with a complicated look: “It seems… things

aren’t easy for you either.”

Then he grew quiet, as if he felt tired after recalling Subspace for so long and wanted to let his mind rest. But in less than half a minute, he suddenly seemed to remember something else.

“There’s something else,” Ted lifted his head, his expression turning serious. “It’s not about Subspace. It’s about… the White Oak.”

“The White Oak?” Duncan looked a bit puzzled. “What about that ship?”

“…I don’t know if it was just my imagination. After all, I was under the influence of Subspace at the time, and my senses and thoughts were a mess. But I kept feeling that something was off when I was talking with that ‘Sailor’ on the White Oak.”

Duncan’s expression turned serious as he listened.

“Sailor… You mean the Anomaly numbered 077? What was wrong with him?”

“I can’t put it into words. But after I came back here, when I thought about how it felt to talk to that Anomaly, I kept feeling that I wasn’t only talking to ‘him’ at the time,” Ted frowned, choosing his words as he tried to remember. “I talked with him about how he saw the world, about the viewpoint of an Anomaly looking at the world. When he answered me… I felt like I could hear more than one voice. It was as if something else was also hiding on that ship, right beside that ‘Sailor’.”

Chapter 694: The Urging Bell

“Captain! You have to believe me! You know how I am—let alone stealing wine from your collection, my legs start cramping the moment I even walk up to your cabin door… I really don’t know how this thing ended up in my hands!”

Anomaly 077 rasped at Lawrence at the top of his lungs. He was so loud that half the deck could hear him. The seafarers passing by all turned to look, curious what trouble the most unusual “member” of the White Oak had stirred up this time.

Lawrence, his hair already gray, only frowned. He ignored the way the mummified corpse howled like a ghost right in front of him and instead stared thoughtfully at the two bottles of beer sitting on the deck beside him.

Of course he believed what the Sailor said. Although this mummified corpse often did many unreliable things, there was one point on which he had always been very reliable: when he saw the captain, his legs really did cramp.

This “anomaly,” who feared the spirit flame like a natural enemy, could not possibly have taken the initiative to sneak into the captain’s cabin to steal anything. Even if these two bottles of beer were lying right there on the table, he would not dare touch them.

After thinking for a moment, Lawrence suddenly raised his head and said: “…Mr. Ted Riel just left? He was with you the whole time before he left?”

The Sailor froze for a second. He did not know why the captain suddenly turned the topic in this direction, but he still hurried to nod: “Yeah, he just left. Before he went, he was chatting with me the whole time.”

Lawrence fixed his gaze on Anomaly 077’s eyes: “What were you talking about?”

“…Poetry and songs?” Anomaly 077 answered without thinking, then quickly waved his hands before the old captain’s face could change. “Of course not… It was something like worldviews or something? I don’t really remember clearly. We seemed to talk about a lot. I just felt that Mr. Ted, that Truth Keeper, was weighed down with worries, and he talked to me about the world, the future, life, things like that…”

He trailed off, hesitated, then muttered, a little uncertain: “I think I even offered him a drink, but he didn’t take it… Weird, did I actually offer or not…”

Lawrence’s brow furrowed slightly. He watched the mummified corpse’s expression and movements with a grave look. After the other had mumbled for a long time, he finally asked: “Then do you still remember how you answered him? Do you remember what you said?”

The Sailor stopped muttering at once. After a moment of trying to recall, his face slowly turned confused and uneasy.

“I… kind of don’t remember? I should have told him a lot, but I can only recall a few lines… Most of the time it felt like I was just babbling nonsense…” Anomaly 077 muttered, looking nervously at the captain. “Wait, I remember now… I didn’t mean to start talking, but back then there was always another voice talking along with me, pushing me to speak… Captain, that feels kind of wrong, doesn’t it?”

“It is wrong… of course it’s wrong,” Lawrence said softly. As he spoke, a faint layer of eerie green flame quietly rose at his side and flowed out across the deck. At the same time, a vast dark silhouette silently surfaced on the sea beside the White Oak—the Black Oak appeared like a reflection rising from the deep. Its hull was wrapped in black mist, lights flickering, its outline shifting and unsteady.

Anomaly 077 jumped in fright at the sudden movement. He hopped back, dodging the spirit flame spreading over the deck, and shouted: “Hey, Captain, what are you doing…”

“An uninvited guest came aboard—though he may already have left,” Lawrence said casually after giving Anomaly 077 a glance. “Martha told me she saw a figure in the White Oak’s reflection that does not belong to any of us. At one point that figure was standing right next to you.”

The Sailor went blank for a second. His expression slowly twisted into horror: “…Holy crap!”

…

“Your judgment was correct. There really was an uninvited guest on the White Oak then—he was right near Anomaly 077,” Duncan nodded to Ted Riel. “You felt you ‘heard’ two voices. One of them should have come from that uninvited guest.”

Ted Riel had noticed the change in Duncan’s expression a moment ago and now spoke, guessing: “…Did the White Oak send you a message? Did that old captain catch him?”

“No,” Duncan shook his head. “The other side was very alert. By the time Lawrence and Martha noticed something, he had already left the ship.”

“Left?” Ted Riel looked a little puzzled. “Out on the boundless sea, where could he possibly…”

He suddenly fell silent. As a Truth Keeper, he had already found the most likely answer from his own experience.

Duncan noticed the change in his expression and gently nodded: “Do you still remember what you and that ‘Sailor’ talked about back then?”

“I remember,” Ted Riel answered at once. He quickly went through it in his head, then repeated everything he had discussed with the “Sailor” without leaving anything out.

As he listened, Duncan’s face grew more and more serious. In the end he nodded: “As I thought… There is no way that Sailor could have said those things on his own.”

Ted Riel looked puzzled: “How can you be so sure?”

“He isn’t that well educated.”

Ted Riel: “…”

“Looks like we can basically confirm the uninvited guest’s identity,” Duncan let out a slow breath. “That set of theories sounds a bit like the Doomsday rhetoric of a Ender, but it’s more like a milder, more logical version. The one talking to you should have been a Ender in a rational state. He hid on the White Oak and spoke to you through the Sailor’s mouth.”

He paused, then added: “Based on what Lawrence reported, the whole thing looked like a kind of mental ‘overwriting’ and ‘mental guidance.’ The Sailor still remembers talking with you, but he can’t recall the details of the conversation. He also did some things that don’t fit his usual personality. That should also be the effect of this influence.”

Ted Riel frowned. His expression turned a bit strange: “…I’ve never heard of Enders having this kind of ability or working this way…”

“That’s normal. Not long ago we didn’t even believe there were rational Enders in this world,” Duncan shrugged. “This group of ‘Subspace worshipers’ who live in the cracks of time have always been the most mysterious of all. Sometimes they act like monsters twisted by Subspace. Sometimes they look like polite scholars. They live in a non-linear time stream, so strictly speaking… maybe no one in the whole world has ever met a ‘complete’ Ender. Everything we know about them so far is only the temporary state they show in one specific ‘time slice.’”

“…An interesting theory,” Ted Riel raised an eyebrow, then smoothed his expression and spoke in a more serious tone. “A Ender could show up right under my nose, get away safe and sound in the end, and not even alert that old captain under your command… It seems their strangeness really is beyond imagination. But after that ‘uninvited guest’ did all this, it was only to borrow the Sailor’s mouth to preach some spooky Doomsday theory to me… What do you think of what he said?”

Duncan did not answer at once. He fell silent and thought over the words Ted Riel had heard from the “Sailor.” After a long time, he suddenly looked up: “What about you? Do you think patching this world up has any meaning?”

“It’s not about whether it has meaning. It’s that there isn’t any other way,” Ted Riel shook his head lightly. “The world is a great ship sailing on the sea. Maybe it really is like the Ender said: this ship is leaking, it is sinking, and it has already reached the point of no cure. But what else can we, who live on the ship, do? The only thing we can do is patch it and patch it again. That is still better than sitting and waiting to die, isn’t it?”

Duncan did not agree or disagree. He only sank into a long silence, and no one knew what he was thinking about at that moment.

Just then, a faint, unreal bell suddenly rang in Ted Riel's ears, cutting off his talk with Duncan.

The Truth Keeper froze on the spot for a second. After he picked out the bell's rhythm and interval, he slowly frowned in confusion: "The Swift Bell…?"

"The Swift Bell?" Duncan's voice came from beside him. "You mean this sudden bell that just rang?"

"Yes. It's the summons for the Saints to go to…" Ted Riel answered without thinking, but stopped halfway. He turned to Duncan with a shocked look. "Wait, you heard that bell too?!"

"Yeah, I heard it. What is it?" Duncan looked puzzled. "Should I not have heard it? It was pretty obvious…"

"Of course you shouldn't have!" Ted Riel almost jumped out of his chair. "That's the summoning bell from the Nameless King's Tomb. Many years ago, the Four Gods Church built seals and mental guidance around this bell. In theory, only the Saints of the Four Gods should be able to hear the summons…"

"The Nameless King's Tomb?" Duncan began to react. "Ah, Vanna did mention something like this to me before. So that's what she meant by the 'Swift Bell'…"

As he spoke, he stood up and looked around, then said offhandedly: "The bell is ringing again—it seems it's urging the Saints to gather. Are you supposed to take part in the assembly?"

"In theory, yes…" Ted Riel said, but then suddenly hesitated. "But this shouldn't be happening… We are still in the Deep Sea Church's duty period. Technically, even I shouldn't be able to hear the bell…"

He raised his head and stared at Duncan. Duncan stared back.

The bell rang yet again, carrying a solemn air, carrying a note of urgency, as if it was preparing to make a grand proclamation to the world.

Chapter 695: An Unprecedented Situation

When the bell rang, Vanna had just finished her evening prayer on the deck. She stepped into the corridor, ready to return to her room, and saw Morris hurrying into the corridor from the other side.

With just one glance, she guessed something from the serious look on Morris's face.

"You also heard the call of the Swift Bell?"

"Yes. Looks like you heard it too," Morris nodded. "The bell has rung three times already—I was just about to hold the psychic resonance ritual."

"…But it's still the Deep Sea Church's duty period," Vanna widened her eyes a little as soon as she heard that. "How could you hear the bell?"

Morris let out a slow breath: "I don't know. That's why we need to go to the assembly and figure out what happened… It seems we are dealing with an unprecedented situation."

Seeing the grave look on the old scholar's face, Vanna thought of the string of unsettling events lately. Then she nodded silently. The two passed each other and went back to their rooms.

The soft sound of the sea echoed in her ears. The feeling of being submerged in water slowly wrapped around her. Vanna hurried back to her room and began the ritual. She watched the candles on the stand in front of

her burn and swell in her sight. The jumping flames turned into a hazy glare. Her restless mood slowly calmed with the sound of the waves.

After a brief dizziness and a reset of her senses, she opened her eyes again and found she had arrived, in the form of a spirit projection, at that sacred ancient “assembly ground.”

Majestic stone pillars stood at the far end of the vast plaza. Chaotic darkness and never-ending streams of light swirled above the pillars. The ground was covered in old stone slabs, mottled and cracked. All across this huge assembly ground, the spirit projections of the Saints were gathering in a rush.

Vanna stood in a corner of the plaza, a bit stunned. She stared wide-eyed at the countless vague figures all around her. She had never seen so many spirit projections appear in the assembly ground at the same time. There was no doubt that these could not all be the Saints of the storm goddess.

It was clear that Morris was not the only Outer Gods believer who had heard the bell during the Deep Sea Church’s duty period.

All the Saints of the four Churches had gathered!

And people were still arriving. More and more spirit projections appeared on the open spaces of the plaza, many of them looking like they had arrived in a rush. Though it was indeed the Deep Sea Church’s duty period, every Saint who heard the Swift Bell still obeyed the iron rule agreed on by the Four Gods Church. As soon as the bell rang, they answered without hesitation and came to this assembly ground as fast as they could.

The dazed and confused spirit projections gathered together, buzzing as they discussed this unusual situation. Vanna walked among her fellow believers, listening to the talk around her as she headed toward the center of the plaza.

A hazy figure came over from the side and greeted her: “Vanna! I was looking for you—what is going on?”

Vanna turned toward the voice and at once recognized Bishop Valentine’s spirit projection. She nodded to him, then shook her head: “I don’t know either. But it looks like every qualified Saint from the four Churches heard the summoning bell… Mr. Morris should be here in the assembly ground too.”

“…The Swift Bell is sounded by the Pilgrimage Ark, but its source lies in the ‘direction’ from the Nameless King’s Tomb. If every Saint received the summons, the only explanation is that the Nameless King’s Tomb has actively sent out a strong signal to ‘gather everyone’…” Bishop Valentine’s tone was grave. He turned his head and fixed his gaze on the still-empty center of the plaza. Only after a long time did he look away. “This ancient covenant ritual has run stably for thousands of years, and nothing like this has ever happened.”

“…Maybe it’s connected to the recent ‘extinguishing of the Sun.’ Some great change is getting closer…” Vanna said softly. Then she suddenly felt something and looked to the side.

Another hazy figure, but one with a familiar aura, appeared in her sight.

It was Morris’s spirit projection.

Vanna at once walked toward him. Before she got close, she heard him speak first: “It seems things are just as I thought. I’m not the only extra one who heard the bell.”

“Yes. It looks like all the Saints are here… Maybe we should be thankful this place is big enough,” Vanna sighed, her tone a bit odd. “The ‘tomb’ itself hasn’t appeared yet. When it does… I don’t know what it’s going to proclaim to us.”

Morris did not answer. He only nodded seriously. After greeting Bishop Valentine, whom he had not seen for some time, he turned with Vanna to look toward the center of the plaza.

Just then, four special figures appeared in the Saints' field of view, one after another.

Helena, Rune, Banster, and Frem—the heralds of the Four Gods—entered the assembly ground. Among the many vague, ghostly spirit projections, their clear forms were especially striking.

The appearance of the four Popes caused a brief stir, but it soon died down. The Saints restored order and quickly calmed down thanks to the presence of their leaders.

Today's situation was far from normal. Many of the Saints who had heard the bell "extra" were confused and uneasy. Even so, the appearance of their leaders was a comforting sign. At the very least, it meant the present situation was still under the Church's control.

Then Vanna noticed that the four Popes, the four Your Eminences, were walking straight toward her.

Her expression suddenly turned a bit awkward.

Under many gazes, full of gaze and formal greetings, Helena and Rune and the others stopped in front of Vanna. Helena spoke first: "The tomb hasn't appeared yet?"

Vanna froze for a second: "Uh… not yet…"

"Good," Helena nodded. "Then we'll wait a little."

Vanna did not even have time to react. She just nodded along in a daze: "… All right."

Then the four Popes really did turn around and start patiently waiting with Vanna for that ancient, mysterious tomb to appear.

Vanna felt her mood grow very strange. She sensed that old Mr. Morris beside her was also giving her a slightly puzzled look, but she had no idea how to explain any of this. She could only give an awkward smile—she did not even know if, in this hazy spirit projection form, Morris could see the complicated look on her face.

Just then, another especially tall figure somehow appeared beside Vanna. He reached out and patted this Inquisitor miss on the shoulder: “Will we have to wait long?”

Vanna did not turn around. She answered naturally without thinking: “Hard to say, but usually the tomb shows up a few minutes after all the Saints arrive at the venue…”

She suddenly stopped.

The space around her seemed to fall silent at once.

Banster and Frem’s expressions froze a little. Helena and Rune’s necks turned stiff as they slowly turned their heads. Vanna also slowly turned and looked toward the source of the voice—

Duncan was standing there, looking (in his opinion) completely harmless as he faced the familiar people in front of him.

After a moment of silence, Vanna finally let out a cry that shattered the stillness: “Captain?! Why are you here?!”

Her cry was like a stone thrown into water. The brief quiet over the assembly ground at once turned into a roaring boil. Shouts of surprise rose one after another. Explosive discussions burst out in waves. Many spirit projections stepped back in shock. Tension, vigilance, and astonishment flooded outward in an instant and spread through the crowd.

Exactly as expected.

Duncan glanced back at the commotion over the plaza, then turned and spread his hands with a helpless look: “To be honest, I didn’t think there would be this many people.”

Vanna felt her brain start to lag. The Popes, however, had already reacted. They spoke in unison, giving a loud order—

“Silence!”

A great power went out with their words. Helena, Rune, Banster, and Frem swept their will over the entire assembly ground. Duncan did not know exactly what they did, but he could feel that the crowd, which had been slipping into chaos just a second ago, suddenly seemed to understand and accept the situation. Although unease still flowed through the air, order had been restored in the assembly ground.

Once order was restored, Helena turned her head first. She fixed her gaze on Duncan: “How did you come here?”

Duncan thought for a moment, then raised his hand and lightly swept it through the air beside him.

A skeletal roc wrapped in green flame flashed through the darkness.

“I came by pigeon.”

Helena: “…?”

“I heard the bell,” Duncan said when he noticed the rich, complicated looks on the Popes’ faces. After thinking for a moment, he added: “Don’t ask me the exact reason—when the bell rang, I just heard it. Then I noticed the gathering of spirit forms. Maybe because the four Pilgrimage Arks are all in Lightwind Harbor right now, this ‘gathering’ was very obvious to me, like lights in the night… I’ve always been curious about your ‘assembly,’ so I

decided to give it a try. Mostly I tried following Vanna's soul-starlight, and I ended up here."

Helena stared, dumbfounded: "…That works?!"

Duncan thought seriously, then nodded: "I think it works."

Helena: "…"

Vanna seemed already used to this. As soon as Duncan said "I think it works," she accepted the situation as a matter of course (mainly because the athlete's ability to adapt to new environments was very strong) and said: "Then what do you think about today's special situation?"

"I don't know," Duncan said very honestly. "This is my first time here. What do you usually do after you all gather? Is there some kind of procedure?"

"We wait for Vision 004—Nameless King's Tomb to appear," Frem's deep voice sounded beside him. He always seemed calm and steady, even now, his tone still as formal as ever. "Then a gravekeeper appears. The chosen one will be led into the tomb chamber."

Duncan listened with great interest and slowly nodded.

As if to prove Frem's words, a low rumble suddenly rose from the center of the plaza, at last breaking off all conversation!

Chapter 696: The Tomb That Felt Wrong

When that low, muffled rumble rang out, Duncan's attention at once shifted to the open space in the center of the square.

He saw the patch of mottled, ancient stone slabs suddenly begin to rise and fall like flowing sand. Some huge structure slowly floated up from deep below the ground. What first came into view was a gray-white spire. A moment later, an ancient and mysterious tomb, like a giant combination of pyramid and palace, slowly rose into his sight.

Solemn and silent, old and austere, the "tomb" made of some kind of gray-white monoliths simply stood there not far away. It looked like time itself had been frozen into a block and set down in this dim chaos. Duncan stared in surprise at the huge building rising from the ground. Driven by curiosity, he studied its style and structure, only to find that it did not match any architectural style he knew from the Age of City-States.

It looked more like the architecture of the Kingdom of Critt he had seen in some old books.

All across the square, the Saints' spirit projections also fell quiet. Countless gazes were drawn, almost against their will, to the giant pyramid tomb. A solemn, tense air spread over the assembly ground, and the whole place became utterly silent.

Several more minutes passed. Just when Vanna and Morris both began to frown in doubt and wonder if something had gone wrong, some movement

finally came from deep within the tomb. The stone gate, which looked unbearably heavy, slowly began to open with a deep rumble.

The great gate stood wide, revealing the dark corridor within.

The spirit projections gathered in the square fixed their gazes on that gate. The deathly silence lasted a long time, then slowly turned into a faint stir and a low buzz of discussion.

Listening to the low voices from all directions, Duncan realized something seemed off. He frowned and quietly asked Vanna beside him: “What went wrong?”

“…The Gravekeeper didn’t appear.” Vanna also lowered her voice. She seemed uneasy as well as confused. “Under normal conditions, the Gravekeeper should walk out of the gate at this point.”

Duncan’s expression slowly grew heavier.

As time went on, the old and mysterious tomb still stood quietly in the center of the assembly ground, yet the Tomb Keeper who should have appeared still did not show himself. The low chatter on the square spread further and further. For a while, this strange situation even made many people forget about “Captain Duncan,” who had come to the assembly today.

But some others, instead, unconsciously turned their eyes toward Duncan.

Duncan ignored the looks directed at him and walked straight toward Helena.

“It seems you’ve never seen this happen before,” he said bluntly. “What is your plan now? If you don’t have one, I’m going to go check this so?called ‘tomb’ myself.”

“Please wait a moment.” Helena spoke at once. Then she thought for a second and turned to look at Rune and the others beside her. “…We’ll go over and take a look first.”

“Fine.” Rune nodded first, then lifted his gaze and spoke to the spirit projections gathered in the assembly ground: “Everyone else, remain on standby in the square. Do not approach Vision 004.”

With that, he turned around. Together with Helena, Banster, and Frem, he slowly walked toward the solemn tomb in the near distance.

Duncan thought for a moment, then also stepped after them. Rune heard footsteps behind him and glanced back. Duncan casually said: “I’ll just come along and take a look. Relax, I won’t set anything on fire.”

Rune’s expression turned a bit odd for a moment, probably remembering the great blaze that had marked Atlantis’s final moments. Helena hesitated, then looked at Vanna. After a brief pause, she gave a light nod: “Vanna, you come too.”

“Me?” Vanna froze for a second, then quickly reacted and hurried to catch up.

Morris stayed behind with the others in a “safe zone” some distance from the tomb. He watched with nervous eyes as the few figures slowly approached Vision 004.

Duncan followed behind Helena and the others and slowly came to the foot of the solemn gray-white pyramid, in front of the silent, gaping gate.

A deep, dim corridor stretched away from the gate into the distance. The weak lights inside only gave a hazy glow to the outline of the passage. The tomb’s interior seemed far more vast and deep than it looked from outside. The corridor appeared endless; he could not see its end at a glance.

Frem bent down beside the gate, as if carefully checking something. Rune pressed his hand on certain spots on the outer wall of the tomb. Near where his palm touched, faint lights like runes briefly floated in the air and flashed before vanishing.

Helena and Banster seemed to be praying in silent benediction, while also keeping watch for something.

Duncan watched the scene with some curiosity and could not help asking: “What are you doing?”

“In ancient times, this ‘Nameless King Tomb’ went through a period when it could not be controlled. During that time, it randomly summoned chosen people from all over the world and caused many terrible events. Later, the Church of the Four Gods acted together and finally placed a shackle on this old, self-running ‘Vision’.” Rune explained casually as he checked the hidden state runes around the tomb. “Those contracts, witnessed by the Four Gods, set rules for the original, chaotic ‘summoning’ behavior of Vision 004. Only then did we get the current Swift Bell and assembly system…”

Duncan raised his eyebrows: “That sounds like some kind of containment measure.”

“Only limited ‘use’.” Rune shook his head. “Visions cannot be contained. But by grasping their patterns, we can cut their harm to the lowest level, and even put them to work. Vision 004 is still running on its own just like in the past. We’ve only found a way to draw information from it without getting killed…”

Visions cannot be contained…

As he listened to Rune’s casual words, Duncan’s expression turned a bit strange.

He thought of the Vanished—strictly speaking, the Vanished was now in a state of containment, and this “Captain Duncan” was the containment condition for the Vanished.

Yet this one exception still fit the “Clause Zero rule” for Anomalies and Visions…

Duncan shook his head and pushed aside these stray thoughts that had suddenly popped up. At the same time, he heard Frem break the silence in a deep voice: “Looks fine.”

“Yes, everything seems normal.” Rune also finished his first round of checks. The elderly Elf straightened up and took two steps back. He looked up at the grand pyramid tomb, his face very serious. “At least… on the outside.”

“If everything outside is normal, then the problem can only be inside.” Duncan spoke softly. He stepped back to the main gate of the tomb and looked at the dark corridor that seemed to have no end. “So what is your plan now?”

Frem walked over. Under Duncan’s curious gaze, the tall, silent Senkin Pope raised his staff and tapped it on the ground three times, not too hard and not too soft.

The next second, a vague shadow suddenly split off from beside him. In the blink of an eye it solidified, taking on the form of another Frem.

“This is my historical avatar form from one hour ago.” Frem turned and explained to Duncan in passing. At the same moment, the “historical avatar form” had already stepped forward with firm steps and, under everyone’s gaze, crossed the gate of Vision 004.

The tall figure walked into the dimness. Vanna moved to stand near Duncan, watching with some tension as it went deeper into the corridor.

Then she saw the figure suddenly stop at some point.

“Why did it stop?” Duncan turned his head and asked in confusion.

Frem also frowned. Even he, the Summoner himself, did not know why his historical avatar form suddenly stopped on the spot. He stared at the sight deep inside the gate of Vision 004 and raised his hand to sketch a few runes in the air, as if trying to rebuild his link with the avatar form. But at that moment a great wave of unease suddenly surged into his mind!

Almost at the same time, the historical avatar form that had been standing still in the dim corridor trembled slightly, as if slowly turning its head.

Frem, standing outside the gate of Vision 004, instantly changed color. He jerked up his staff and, even as he cut off the summoning, he called out at once: “Careful, corruption!”

The next second, he cleanly severed the summoning and ordered the historical avatar form to dissolve. But only a brief, dim glow flickered at the top of his staff. The tall avatar form standing in the corridor of Vision 004 did not vanish at all. Instead, after a slight shudder, it continued to turn its head.

Like a strange corpse, the tall, pale figure twisted its head around. Its face, slowly turning in the Shadows, had already begun to warp into horrible shapes and dark hollows. A torn, chilling smile spread across that chaotic face. In the dim glow, that ripped grin bloomed in the dark like the mad laughter of a lunatic. Layers upon layers of mutters, whispers, and weird howls seemed to ring at once in almost everyone’s ears!

The ghastly scene made everyone’s hair stand on end. Banster and the others reacted at once, instantly ready to respond to corruption and fight a powerful enemy. Even if it was only a historical avatar form that had entered the tomb, it was still the Flamebearer Pope’s avatar form. Any

power that could corrupt and drag it down in an instant was clearly no ordinary thing!

But just then, a tall figure stepped forward and moved ahead of everyone, blocking the gate and cutting off the “historical avatar form’s” line of sight.

Duncan’s body rose in layer upon layer of unreal fire. In the crackling surge of spirit flame, a wall of ghostly green fire almost covered the entire gate. He stood in the flames, fixing his gaze on the figure in the distance that had already been corrupted by some power.

“Why did you stop turning?”

Chapter 697: Phantoms in the Tomb

ghostly green flame lit up the entrance of the corridor and made the dim lights farther in look even more heavy and oppressive. In that unsettling gloom, the corrupted “historical avatar form” suddenly went still, like a stone statue standing in the distance, deaf to Duncan’s words.

But that silent and eerie standoff lasted only a short time. Before Duncan’s eyes, the “historical avatar form” that had been frozen for only a few seconds suddenly shook again, and in the next moment it snapped its head around!

Its once-human features had twisted into dark hollows and swirling pits. Only the torn crazy smile still spread across that scrambled face. It twisted its body at angles no Human could make. In an instant, its four limbs turned into tentacles that clung to the walls and ceiling. With a sudden burst of sharp, chaotic screeching, this terrifying, freakish thing hurled itself at Duncan without a hint of fear!

Duncan frowned at once. The next second, blazing ghostly green spirit flame flooded the entire corridor.

Flames rose in layer upon layer of walls, filling everyone’s sight. The corrupted horror screamed, laughed, and burned as it ran madly toward the exit of the tomb. It forced its way through one barrier of spirit flame after another. It even pushed forward until it was less than four or five meters

from Duncan before the burning wreck finally collapsed to the floor, twitching once and then going completely still.

Several minutes later, the flames slowly faded.

Duncan, still frowning, carefully walked up to the remains that had almost been burned to ash. In the ashes there was only a shriveled, charred lump. He had left it on purpose by controlling the fire. Any trait that had once marked it as Senkin was completely gone, but there was still a twisted crack on it, like a laughing mouth frozen in place on the blackened lump, filled with a chilling, crazed joy.

After hesitating for a moment, he picked up the last bit of remains with a strange feeling, then cautiously backed out of the corridor of Vision 004 and returned to the gate.

The few people waiting outside the gate hurried over at once. With tense and uneasy faces, they looked at the “charcoal” Duncan had brought out. Helena stared at the torn mark that looked like a smile on the remains. After a while, she lifted her hand and lightly traced the mark of the Storm Goddess over her chest. “Goddess protect us… Frem, that’s the ugliest smile I’ve ever seen.”

“I’m just glad you can still joke at a time like this.” Banster glanced at Helena and shook his raspy head. Then his attention returned to the remains. “…It’s the smell of Subspace.”

“How could there be Subspace power inside Vision 004?” Rune frowned hard and glanced up at the tomb gate beside him. “It’s always been dangerous, but its danger lay in the strict rules inside the tomb and in that powerful, eerie Gravekeeper. I’ve never heard that it carried the power of Subspace…”

Duncan thought for a moment and asked: “What is the structure inside the tomb like? And what kind of being is this so?called ‘Nameless King’?”

The people present all looked at each other. After a brief, awkward silence, it was Vanna who finally answered the captain’s question: “Aside from knowing a few basic ‘rules of conduct,’ no one knows the true shape of the inside of the tomb.”

Duncan looked confused at once: “No one knows?”

“When a Listener leaves Vision 004, they forget all memories about the interior of the tomb. Only a small part of the information is brought out in the form of parchment sheet fragments. All we can be sure of is that there is a burial chamber inside Vision 004, and some ancient and mysterious being waits in that chamber for the Listener’s visit,” Vanna explained patiently. “But no one remembers what the chamber actually looks like or what the master of the chamber looks like.”

“Protective forgetting…” Duncan softly repeated the words. Then, all of a sudden, he seemed to sense something. He quickly looked up at the gate of the tomb.

Heavy, slow footsteps suddenly echoed in the corridor. A tall, grim figure walked into view with the sound of those steps.

The Gravekeeper of Vision 004 appeared!

The Gravekeeper, “late” by quite a long time, simply walked out like this. Even Duncan did not see how he had emerged. It was as if the tomb itself had suddenly “generated” a body. This eerie Gravekeeper stepped with stiff, corpse-like, heavy steps toward them. The chains coiled around him gave off sharp, scraping sounds with each movement.

Helena and the others tensed at once. Vanna leaned forward a little without thinking, ready to spring into action. Since the Nameless King Tomb was

clearly acting abnormally, the “Gravekeeper” walking out of it was clearly no longer safe.

But the “Gravekeeper” seemed not to care about their guarded stances. He simply walked out slowly as usual and finally stopped in front of Duncan.

After a brief silence, the tall Guard, wrapped head to toe in bandages and seeming caught between life and death, turned slightly to the side. He raised a hand and pointed toward the passage, making a silent gesture of invitation.

Duncan raised his eyebrows: “You want me to go in?”

The Tomb Guardian slowly nodded.

“Be careful,” Rune warned in a low voice at once. “Something is wrong here.”

Duncan ignored him. He calmly fixed his gaze on the cloudy eyes that showed through the bandages of the Tomb Guardian. After a few seconds, he suddenly said: “And what if I refuse the invitation?”

The Tomb Guardian fell silent. Just when everyone thought this special entity, created by Vision 004, would not answer at all, it actually spoke. A low voice came from under the bandages: “Then when will you have time?”

Duncan: “…”

He froze for a heartbeat, and in that moment the Tomb Guardian spoke again: “His time is running out.”

“‘His’? Running out of time?” Duncan blinked in surprise, and his expression changed at once. “You mean the master of the tomb? What do you mean, ‘running out of time’?”

This time, the Tomb Guardian did not reply. He simply stood quietly before Duncan, saying nothing and yet somehow saying everything.

“…All right.” After two minutes of serious thought, Duncan suddenly nodded. “Then I’ll go see ‘him’.”

As soon as he spoke, Helena beside him said at once: “Are you sure? The situation inside Vision 004 right now—”

“Subspace doesn’t count as corruption for me.” Duncan shook his head. He had clearly made up his mind. “I heard the ‘bell.’ It seems this round was prepared for me. My gut tells me I shouldn’t refuse this ‘invitation’.”

“Your gut…” Helena was stunned for a moment. Then she seemed to realize something, and she pulled back the words she had meant to say and stepped half a pace away. “All right. I understand.”

The Tomb Guardian slowly turned his head and looked at Helena, Rune, and the others.

“Keep your distance. Do not cross the facility gate again,” he suddenly said. “The C-32-E7 Protocol Tree is unstable.”

Helena and the others all froze at his words. Rune spoke before he could stop himself: “…What protocol tree?”

But the Tomb Guardian did not seem inclined to answer. He only stepped to the side and opened the way to the passage, once more making an inviting gesture to Duncan.

Duncan gave the Guard a deep look, then stepped forward. Before entering the passage, he glanced back at the anxious Vanna standing behind the others and gave her a small nod: “Wait in peace. I’ll be back soon.”

As soon as he finished speaking, he walked into the long, deep, and seemingly endless dark passage.

The heavy gate of the tomb boomed shut, cutting off all sight from outside and blocking all sound from beyond Vision 004. The dim lights on the walls

of the passage burned quietly. A strange dead silence closed in from all directions.

Duncan heard only the heavy footsteps of the Tomb Guardian behind him and the harsh scraping of chains rubbing against each other.

But after walking for a while, he suddenly noticed a change in the footsteps behind him. The sound of chains scraping together had vanished as well.

Curious, he turned his head—and his face showed clear surprise.

A tall, silent man with slightly dark skin, black hair, and a white robe was walking along the passage.

Duncan stared for a second, then suddenly reacted: "…That's what you really look like?"

The tall, dark-skinned man turned his gaze. His pupils were a strange pale gold, and something deep within those eyes seemed to shift, focus, and lock onto Duncan. Then he gave a slight nod. "Yes."

Duncan frowned, but just as he was about to ask something else, something at the edge of his vision caught his eye and broke his train of thought.

Far ahead in the passage, a shape like a crossroads had appeared at some unknown time. The junction floated and flickered as if it were an illusion. In front of that phantom crossroads, a group of vague figures in white robes suddenly appeared and were walking toward the distance.

They passed through the ghostly crossroads, walked along the deep, long passage, and then vanished into the solid, heavy wall on the opposite side.

Duncan watched the scene in surprise and curiosity and could not help asking: "What is that?"

"As the protocol tree falls out of balance, the folding and disorder of the Time-Stream are rolling back toward the source—that is a moment from

long ago, when they set out."

Duncan's heart stirred. "They? Who are they?"

The Tomb Guardian, now in Human form again, stayed silent for a few seconds, then answered in a low voice: "…Doomsday Observer, End Survey Team."

Duncan suddenly stopped walking.

His eyes opened a little wider, as if he had linked many things together in an instant. Wild, tangled thoughts surged through his mind. He took a quiet breath and looked up along the long passage ahead. Just then another hazy phantom slid into his blurred view.

Another figure in a white robe was walking toward them.

It was a young man with short black hair. He walked with head held high and shoulders straight. His eyes were calm yet firm. He strode down the corridor, and in the instant they passed each other—maybe it was just his imagination—Duncan felt that the figure's eyes seemed to shift, ever so slightly, in his direction.

Then they passed by each other and went on.

Chapter 698: The Figure on the throne

The figure with short black hair and a white robe brushed past him. That brief sideways glance as they crossed paths felt almost like an illusion born in Duncan's own mind. He saw the figure walk toward the depths of Vision 004 and, after passing through a wall, silently vanish from his sight.

Doomsday Observer… Doomsday Survey Team…

Those names, which naturally led to all kinds of associations, finally stirred a curiosity Duncan could no longer hold back. He turned to the tall guide beside him and asked: "What is their mission?"

"Enter the Time-Stream. Within the knowable range of time, confirm whether the Sanctuary World is running according to the Creator's original Blueprint, and determine the timestamp of the system's collapse."

The Tomb Guardian spoke calmly as he stepped forward again, leading Duncan deeper into the tomb of the Nameless King.

But the Gravekeeper's answer had already stirred up waves in Duncan's heart.

Observers who traveled through the Time-Stream, survey teams that tracked Doomsday… was it really them?!

Duncan suddenly raised his head. His gaze swept over the old-fashioned walls and pillars lining the corridor around him, and another thought quickly came to him: "What exactly is this place?"

As soon as he asked, he felt something strange. It sounded like a question he already knew the answer to, yet for some reason he felt that the Gravekeeper before him would understand what he really meant.

The Gravekeeper's steps paused for a barely noticeable moment.

"This is the first Critt observation post—and it will also be the last," the deep, calm voice reached Duncan's ears. "A very, very long time ago, there were one thousand two hundred such Doomsday observation posts, and we directly controlled ten of them."

Duncan froze for a moment. All at once, he remembered a passage he had read before—

"…To avoid repeating the failure of the King of Dreams and the pale king of giants, He divided the Blueprint, so that there would no longer be many nations in the mortal world, and the nations would become one thousand two hundred cities. He gave the first ten cities to that clan to rule, and granted them the name 'Critt'…"

The stylistic features of Vision 004 now had an explanation—it really was a relic left by the ancient kingdom of Critt. This relic had been running for ten thousand years, and even after becoming a "Vision", it still kept operating!

At the same time, what had been recorded in that Blasphemous Tome was once again confirmed. The "one thousand two hundred cities" written in the book really existed, but they did not refer to one thousand two hundred city-states. They meant one thousand two hundred Doomsday observation posts!

The people called the Doomsday Survey Team set out from here and entered the Time-Stream to monitor the operation of the Sanctuary World and to determine the "Time Boundary" when the Sanctuary World reached its limit…

A broad scene suddenly appeared at the edge of his vision. Duncan snapped out of his thoughts at once, lifted his head, and looked forward in surprise.

He did not know when, but under the Gravekeeper’s lead he had already walked out of that corridor that seemed to have no end. After they passed through a tall gate, the view before his eyes suddenly opened up—not just open, it hardly even felt like the inside of a “building” anymore!

He saw a plaza, a plaza under a dim yellow sky that looked big enough to hold tens of thousands of people gathered together.

The gate of the corridor where Duncan stood was high above the ground. A sloping stone ramp led down from it to the edge of the plaza. The plaza itself was covered with huge, flat slabs of gray-white stone, and a wide walkway cut straight across it. He also saw solemn pillars with a faint metallic sheen standing on both sides of the road. There seemed to have been more complex structures on top of those pillars, but they had weathered and fallen apart over the long corruption of the years. All around the plaza he could see all kinds of collapsed, leaning ruins, as if they had once been many gates and pillars. The only thing in sight that remained whole was the huge throne in the center of the plaza.

That pitch-black throne stood in the center of the plaza. Its back rose high, as if it were looking down on everything around it. A hazy, dim light, like the sky at dusk, hung over the plaza. Under that yellowish glow, the ruins before his eyes seemed wrapped in a near?eternal… loneliness.

For some reason, a desolate feeling rose in Duncan’s heart. It seemed that these collapsed, dust-covered ruins brought with them a heavy air that he could not help but feel.

The white-robed Tomb Guardian had already passed Duncan. He stepped onto the sloping ramp and walked in silence toward the plaza that had turned into ruins.

Duncan hesitated for a moment, then followed in silence.

They walked down the slope and reached the wide walkway that cut through the entire plaza. They moved forward slowly between two rows of tall, solemn stone pillars. Duncan’s gaze swept around from time to time, taking in the once splendid and grand structures that were now broken walls and shattered ruins.

From time to time, visions of the past appeared before his eyes. He saw people in long white robes or short gray robes appear beyond the pillars. They hurried across the plaza, some walking toward the abandoned gates at the edges, others gathering in places to talk, as if they were discussing something.

He could almost imagine how busy and important this place had once been. In the years of the Genesis Protocol, when the Crawling King was still adjusting the Blueprint of the New World, and when the ancient kingdom of Critt still acted as the Creator’s “assistant” in shaping this world, they had gathered here. They had worked and rushed about for the founding of the Sanctuary World and made plans for the growth of civilization over the next ten thousand years.

At that time, the Great Annihilation had just ended. The long chain of ruins left by the Great Collision still floated over the mortal world, and the order of all things rose and fell from dawn to dusk.

At that time, the meetings of the Elder Kings were held again and again. Two Long Nights had already failed, but the third Long Night was beginning to show a hint of dawn.

At that time, the troops known as the Doomsday Survey Team passed through the Veil of time as a vanguard force to check the boundaries of the Sanctuary World—the boundaries along the axis of time.

At that time, the Boundless Sea had perhaps only just taken shape, the city-states had not yet been built, and “the Sun” had not yet risen. The first Humans still slept in the Crawling King’s database. In the endless Long Night, only the lights of the ancient kingdom of Critt briefly lit up this chaotic world…

Back then, this place had not yet become Vision 004. There were still one thousand one hundred and ninety-nine other observation posts like it scattered among the ashes of the Great Annihilation, all waiting for the moment when the New World would be opened.

Now, all of that had already blown away with the wind.

Only this desolate, crumbling ruin remained, drifting in a gap outside the Mortal Realm, stirring Duncan’s thoughts and endless guesses deep in his heart.

The tall Tomb Guardian walked slowly ahead of Duncan, as if strolling through a corridor of time. When another team of the Doomsday Survey Team passed between the pillars, he suddenly broke the silence and said: “They have not sent any news back for a very long time.”

“…They went mad,” Duncan said softly.

“Oh.”

The Tomb Guardian nodded and kept walking slowly forward.

After a while, he spoke again, as if talking to himself: “At the beginning, they sent back a lot of information. Within the first Communication Cycle after they set out, they sent back news of the Age of City-States. After that came the rise and fall of the Far Sea Alliance in the darkness.

“They mentioned the disappearance of the kingdom of Critt and happily mentioned the appearance of ‘the Sun’. In the reports they sent back, there were many unbelievable things that did not seem to fit the Blueprint’s

design, yet in the Creator's later calculations, the appearance of those things all seemed inevitable…"

The Gravekeeper stopped. He lifted his head to look at the huge, dark throne in the center of the plaza. After a long silence, he shook his head slightly.

"After that, their messages grew fewer and fewer. Sometimes… there were even things we could not understand. It seemed they had dived very deep into the Time-Stream, or gone very far along it. That had already gone beyond our original plan…

"Many times, the messages they sent back contradicted each other, or came in a scrambled order. This happened more and more often later on. The Creator's calculations judged this to be normal, because the Sanctuary World is a finite model. It takes this place as its center, like a lamp lighting up a wilderness, and time is the distance that light can reach. The farther away it is, the more the undefined darkness controls everything. At the boundary of time, if they could not find another lamp, that simply meant there was nothing worth reporting…"

The Gravekeeper fell silent again. After an unknown length of quiet, he spoke softly once more, as if to himself: "They have not sent any news back for a very long time…"

Duncan said nothing.

He had already reached the black throne that looked as if it had been made for giants. He slowly lifted his eyes and looked at the figure on the throne.

A headless body sat quietly on the throne. Countless thick cables and pipes wound around it like veins and nerves stretching out from its flesh. They connected every part of the body and linked it to the countless ports and slots on the throne. Some of those ports still blinked with faint lights, and a

kind of flowing glow that seemed almost alive moved through some of the pipes, constantly pouring into the body and then flowing back out again.

The moment he saw the headless body on the throne, Duncan's eyes changed slightly. He suddenly remembered the scene Ted Riel had once described to him, something Ted had seen in Subspace. But more than that memory, what shocked him and even left him a little lost was a certain… familiarity coming from that body.

Stunned, he lifted his head and fixed his gaze on the body on the throne. After almost a full minute, he could not hold back and said: "In Subspace, there is a headless body sitting on a pitch-black throne…"

"That is his shadow," the Tomb Guardian said softly. "The Creator took away his body, but could only take a part of it. He was torn into pieces, and it was not only his body that split apart. His memories, soul, shadow, thoughts, his past and his future… all were shattered in the second Long Night. The Creator brought this body here, and the shadow stayed in the place where he first died."

Duncan suddenly turned his head and looked into the Tomb Guardian's eyes. The sense of familiarity he felt from the body on the throne grew stronger and stronger, until he finally could not help but ask: "Who exactly is the one on the throne?"

"Saslokar. The Creator used him as the template to create the first 'Critt' (from 'create')."

Chapter 699: Lonely Vigil

After hearing the Tomb Guardian's answer, Duncan did not speak for a long time. The answer was shocking, yet for some reason it felt as if he had already… expected it in some way.

"…The 'Creator' you keep mentioning, is that the Crawling King? Or rather… the Lord of Abyssal Deep?"

"We usually call him 'Navigator One'," the Tomb Guardian slowly lowered his head and said, "or 'Cluster Controller'. But we also know the names 'Crawling King' and 'Lord of Abyssal Deep'. Those came up in reports the Doomsday Survey Team sent back from a certain time node."

The tall Gravekeeper fell silent for a few seconds after saying this. Then he spoke again, softly, as if talking to himself: "We also have not received any news from the Creator for a very long time."

Duncan did not answer. Chaotic thoughts filled his mind. After a short moment of thinking, he lifted his head and fixed his gaze on the body on the throne: "So, during the third Long Night, 'Navigator One' gathered part of the King of Dreams' remains, then used his special divine authority of 'copying' to design the Critt race after the King of Dreams as a template, to make them his assistants… The entire Critt race was 'made' this way? Including the Doomsday Survey Teams?"

"Of course," the Gravekeeper said in a calm tone. "The world was still very chaotic back then. The Creator had briefly released some mortals into the still-unformed Sanctuary World, but found that they could not survive there

and were far from useful. So he could only seek help from beings as powerful as himself. Saslokar, who had died earlier in the process of the Genesis Protocol, was the most suitable choice."

Duncan quietly listened to the Gravekeeper's explanation, but the look on his face grew more and more strange. He suddenly realized that if he followed this fact to its end… then did that not mean all the Enders could be counted as Saslokar's "spawn"?!

This strange and shocking thought flashed through his mind. Duncan suddenly went blank for a moment, and then could not help linking it to something else—

Those mad "Preachers" had become wildly excited the moment they saw the Vanished and even called it the "Promised Ark"… The main reason behind that was of course that the Vanished had once entered Subspace and returned intact. But could it also… have something to do with the fact that the current Vanished was actually built on Saslokar's "Elder God spine"?!

Could the madness and frenzy of those Enders actually be some kind of stress reaction that "spawn" had when they drew close to an "Elder God"?!

Once these shocking connections appeared, they were hard to stop. Duncan's thoughts raced far away in an instant. Only after a long while did his focus slowly pull back and fall once more on the throne and the headless body before him.

He remembered something the Gravekeeper had said to him before they entered the tomb.

"You said he did not have much time left… You meant this body does not have much time left?"

"He has kept watch here for a very long time, but the maintenance systems here cannot run forever," the Gravekeeper said in a low voice. "The ancient

systems the Creator left behind are all developing problems one after another. They have been in service far beyond their limits. This throne once served as the starting point for one thousand two hundred observation posts and upheld the ‘existence’ of all Critt. But now this place has become the last observation post, and the throne’s operation is also about to reach its end.”

Duncan suddenly frowned: “…What will happen when the throne stops running?”

The Gravekeeper stayed silent for a moment, then slowly said: “It will mean that the first pillar system the Creator left behind has completely collapsed. After that, the fourth Long Night will begin.”

The fourth Long Night!

Duncan’s eyes changed slightly. After so many scattered and messy clues, this was the first time he had received such a clear piece of information, the first time he could confirm what the key node would be when the fourth Long Night came!

And the Gravekeeper had just said that all the ancient systems the Creator left behind were failing. The collapse of the throne was clearly only one of them. Vision 001—the Sun—was without a doubt another system on the verge of its limit… This matched what was already known!

Duncan’s brow furrowed tightly, and his thoughts churned within him—

By common sense, when the first “collapse” appeared in a series of interlinked, complex systems, a chain reaction was sure to follow. In other words, once the throne here stopped running, the malfunctions and final shutdown of the Sun would also speed up…

Every Long Night began with the great collapse at the end of the previous one, and the third Long Night had been no exception. The collapse of the

throne and the shutdown of the tomb of the Nameless King, the last Critt observation post, would start it. After that, the Sun would speed toward its own collapse amid a chain of failures until it went out forever, and the whole world would sink into the veil of night…

The Gravekeeper before him clearly knew many things, some even beyond the age he himself lived in, beyond the Time-Stream up to now. Those pieces of information… perhaps came from the Doomsday Survey Teams that had set out so long ago and watched over the entire Sanctuary World within the Time-Stream…

Thinking of the Gravekeeper who had brought him here, Duncan's thoughts spread out again:

This Gravekeeper and the tomb he warded had already existed in this chaotic gap for ten thousand years. But from what Vanna had revealed, the tomb of the Nameless King had never held such rational, positive contact with the outside as it did today. In the eyes of the world, this tomb was the chaotic and dangerous "Vision 004". Yet now, this Gravekeeper and everything in the tomb seemed very "normal"…

Duncan's train of thought suddenly stopped. He turned his head, deep in thought, and looked at the tall Gravekeeper standing beside him.

…Was it really normal?

Was this, once again, like those "unnameable" beings he had met before, something only he could hear and see clearly? For all those other "Listeners" who had been led into the tomb, did this Tomb Guardian and the ancient plaza ruin at the end of the corridor look completely different?

Duncan remembered the "Cognitive Shift model" Rune had brought up at the gathering not long ago. After thinking for a moment, he could not help asking: "Will the others who enter the tomb see the same things I see?"

“…I try my best to blind their senses and clear away the harmful parts of their memories before they leave. Mortals should not see too many things. It is harmful to them.”

Duncan nodded slowly.

The Gravekeeper’s answer did not fully match what he had expected, but it already indirectly confirmed his guess.

The world he saw was not the same as the one an ordinary person saw. The more things involved “Anomalies” and “Visions”, the stronger this “shift effect” became.

Duncan let out a light breath and set these tangled questions aside for now. After a brief silence, he suddenly asked: “How long is left?”

The Tomb Guardian turned his head: “Hm?”

Duncan lifted his head and pointed at the tall, dark throne: “I mean, how much longer can this throne keep running?”

“I cannot be sure. I am only a Warden, and the Scholars who understood this complex system have been gone for a very long time. The only answer I can give you is… soon.”

“What will happen to this body after the throne stops running?”

This time the Tomb Guardian did not answer at all. He only shook his head in silence.

Duncan did not press further. He and the Gravekeeper simply stood there in silence, in the ruins lit by the dusk-colored sky. After an unknown stretch of time, Duncan suddenly asked: “I heard the bell… Was it because this place is already near its limit? Were you the one actively calling me?”

“Yes.”

“Why?” Duncan turned his head, his expression puzzled and serious. “What do you hope I will do?”

To his surprise, the Gravekeeper shook his head: “I do not know.”

“You do not know?”

“I am only a Warden. The ones who understood everything and knew everything have been gone for a very long time,” the Gravekeeper said, fixing his gaze on Duncan’s eyes. “But I still remember one thing… only one thing.”

He turned around and looked toward the wide ruins in the distance, toward the phantoms that sometimes appeared at the edge of the plaza, hurriedly passing through many gates and slipping in and out of the timeline. Then he spoke softly:

“When they had just set out, a message came from the most distant, most impossible Time Boundary and reached here almost in an instant. It was a single sentence from a Doomsday surveyor who claimed to have already trekked to the very end—

“He said that dusk had fallen, and that the bearer of the Flame Usurper had set this world alight.”

Duncan stayed silent. As he listened to the Gravekeeper, he hid all his feelings in eyes as deep and calm as water. No one knew what he was thinking at that moment.

But the Gravekeeper clearly did not mind. He simply went on calmly: “I do not know what you will think after seeing all of this, and I do not know what you will do on some day in the future. Even more, I do not know what effect the things I have told you today will have on some action or decision you make in the future.

“My duty is only to ward this station and, according to ancient agreements, activate it from time to time so that it can carry out limited data exchange with the outside world. We are a race that was carefully designed and created. Every one of us exists only to complete limited and necessary tasks, and strictly speaking, bringing you here does not fall within my duties.

“But the ones who were in charge of assigning tasks are gone, and there has been no news of the Creator for a very long time. So I feel that I should at least… do something.”

“…I understand,” Duncan let out a quiet breath. At some point his face had relaxed. He looked at the Gravekeeper and nodded slowly and seriously. “Thank you for telling me so much. To know what once happened is already a great gain for me.”

“Then that is good.”

Chapter 700: Return

Duncan stood for a long time in front of that huge black throne.

He knew this was another “shard” of Saslokar after that being had been torn apart. But this shard could no longer leave the throne. In that age when the Deep Sea era was still being laid as a foundation, it had already been made one of the keystones of the Sanctuary World, permanently anchored between the beginning of time and the End, becoming part of the vast system Navigator One had left behind.

But then he suddenly grew curious. Did the other Elder Kings know about this? When the Crawling King decided to build part of the King of Dreams’ remains into the Sanctuary World, how had they talked about it among themselves?

“Make use of everything,” the Gravekeeper answered calmly when faced with Duncan’s question. “Back then they did not have many resources. Everything that could be used had to show its value. If the Creator’s plan failed, he too would have been used in the next plan.”

Duncan nodded slightly, then left the platform where the throne stood. He strolled onto the walkway and walked forward along those mottled, ancient columns. When he was about to reach the end, he suddenly stopped and asked: “Do you have anything else to show me?”

“No,” the Gravekeeper said slowly. “That is all.”

“Then it seems it’s time to leave,” Duncan said. He raised his head and looked at the dusky, chaotic “sky” above, simulated by some unknown light

source. “People outside are still waiting for news.”

“I will see you out,” the Gravekeeper said, lowering his head.

“Mm.” Duncan nodded. But just as he was about to step onto that ramp, he suddenly stopped again, as if he had remembered something: “Right, there’s one more thing.”

The Gravekeeper looked over at him.

“Maybe – maybe – I will meet that ‘Creator’ you spoke of. I still don’t know whether it will go smoothly, and I don’t know what state that ‘Creator’ is in. But if I do see him, is there anything you want me to pass on?”

The Gravekeeper suddenly fell silent. After a long time he slowly shook his head and said: “It would not really mean anything. The facility is about to shut down. After you leave, this place will cut off all contact with the outside world until the system reaches its limit… Even if you really meet our Creator by then, I will no longer receive any news.”

Duncan looked at the Gravekeeper with his gaze for a moment, then nodded in silence.

But just as he turned away, the Gravekeeper suddenly spoke again: “Wait. Please… still help me pass on one message.”

Duncan turned back, his expression especially serious: “Go ahead.”

“Just tell him…” The Gravekeeper hesitated, as if he were searching for the right words. Then, with a strange solemnity, he said: “We were honored to complete our work.”

“I will tell him,” Duncan said with a nod. He turned and walked up the long sloping passage that led back.

The Gravekeeper followed at his side, and in silence he walked with Duncan along the road out of the tomb.

When they were about to reach the exit, the tall Warden suddenly broke the silence and said: “From now on, they no longer have to answer the call. Please remind those shadows gathered outside that no matter what comes from here again, they must not come near this place.

“There will be no new register, and no new guidance. The Sanctuary World has already walked every knowable path that was left in its original design. Our observation has reached its end. Beyond this point lies a future that not even the Creator ever calculated… No one knows what waits in that future.

“I hope that in the days to come, they can all… stay… safe and… well.”

With every word he spoke, the Tomb Keeper’s voice grew more hoarse and deep. With every step he took, his footsteps grew heavier. The marks of time slowly appeared on his body, and the smell of rot and death rose from him. At some point, that pure white robe of his had turned into a tattered, ancient shroud, and chains that seemed to have a sealing power slowly spread out from inside him, winding tighter and tighter around his body.

Then the heavy sound of a door opening came from ahead.

The ancient, solemn gate of the tomb swung open, and Duncan stepped out of Vision 004.

He was the only one in history to ever walk out through that door while still awake.

The figures waiting near the gate rushed over at once. Vanna was the first to reach Duncan. She stepped up to support his arm (even though he did not need the help at all), worry written all over her face as she asked: “Are you all right?”

“Of course I’m fine,” Duncan said casually as he glanced back. But in the dark passage behind him he could no longer see the Gravekeeper’s figure. Only a mass of swelling, writhing shadows was slowly fading in the corridor, and that made him frown. “How long was I inside?”

“Just an instant,” Helena’s voice came from the side. “We heard a short, strange noise from inside the tomb, and then the gate opened again and you walked out.”

“An instant?” Duncan frowned.

“It’s always like that,” Vanna said with a nod. “No matter how long you feel you stayed in the tomb, to the people outside it is always just an instant. The scholars in the Church think it’s because the time stream inside Vision 004 is cut off from the outside world…”

Rune raised his hand and added: “For the record, I was the first to propose that theory a thousand years ago.”

Listening to the voices around him, Duncan stayed silent. He turned and looked at the now silent Vision 004 with his gaze. As he watched, a deep rumble came from within the ancient, solemn tomb, and then it slowly began to sink.

In almost the blink of an eye, that grand Critt structure vanished from everyone’s sight.

At that moment Vanna also noticed the weight and solemnity hidden in Duncan’s expression, and she could not help asking: “In your case… you should still have your memories from inside Vision 004, right? What did you see in the tomb?”

Duncan was silent for a moment, then he nodded slightly.

“What I saw and heard inside Vision 004 should be different from all the previous ‘Listeners’… I learned the truth of how this facility was built, and

the future tied to it. But first…”

He raised his head. His gaze swept over the spirit projections waiting on standby in the assembly ground, then settled on Helena and the other three Popes.

“Have everyone else leave first. After I tell you the truth of what is inside the tomb, you can decide how to explain it to your Saints.”

…

Gentle waves rose and fell outside the window. A fresh sea breeze blew into the room as Alice opened the round porthole on the side of the captain’s cabin to let the air in. She stood in the sunlight and wind, narrowing her eyes in satisfaction.

“The room really needs to be aired out often. The captain always forgets to open the windows,” the doll girl muttered, hands on her hips. She sounded like she was talking to herself, but also like she was nagging all her “friends” scattered everywhere on the ship. “If you leave it closed too long, everything will get moldy!”

No one in the room answered her nagging. Even Goathead, who was usually noisy all the time, was unusually quiet now. He sat by the edge of the enchanted sea chart table with his eyes half-closed, looking almost asleep.

But all of a sudden, Goathead’s head jerked up and started turning from side to side.

He saw the doll Alice cleaning the room beside him, and then saw the “Dream Skull” not far from him. A muffled groan came from his mouth.

Alice hurried over, full of curiosity: “Hey! Mr. Goathead! What’s wrong?”

Goathead slowly worked his neck, the wood creaking as he muttered: “Weird… I feel like I just had a dream.”

Alice widened her eyes in surprise: “Huh? Didn’t you say you can’t dream?”

“That’s why it’s weird…” Goathead grumbled. “The captain says I can dream, but in theory I should never be able to notice myself dreaming… Yet just now I zoned out, and it felt just like a dream.”

Alice’s curiosity was hooked right away. She put the duster aside and sat down across from Goathead: “Now that you mention it, I sometimes suspect I dream too, but every time I wake up I can’t remember anything… Do you remember what you just dreamed?”

Goathead glanced at the curious doll sitting opposite him, and his tone slowly turned strange: “I dreamed… that I was sitting on a very huge chair, and I sat on it for many, many years… A lot of people were running around me, busy with all kinds of things, and then…”

He paused. A frown seemed to appear on his stiff face. “And then there were lots and lots of children… Those people running around… suddenly they all turned into my children…”

Alice propped her chin in both hands and slowly leaned forward. The more she listened, the wider her eyes opened, as if she was shocked by Goathead’s few words. Suddenly she blurted out: “Did they all have Goatheads like you?! How did they run around? Did they hop?”

Goathead froze. “…I think you misunderstood something. That’s not the point…”

But he did not get the chance to correct the doll’s imagination. Just as he was about to go on, the door of the captain’s cabin suddenly opened.

Duncan’s tall figure appeared in the doorway.

Alice instantly forgot what they had been talking about. Smiling, she stood up from behind the enchanted sea chart table and ran toward the door: “The captain is back!”

Duncan casually pinched Alice’s cheek as he stepped into the room.

Goathead turned his head, his eyes falling on Duncan with some confusion: “It seems you went to a… strange place?”

Duncan did not answer his question. He simply walked over to the enchanted sea chart table. After he adjusted his seat, he looked seriously at Goathead on the table and said slowly: “I need to tell you something. Don’t panic…”

Chapter 701: Leaving Port

Right now Goathead was very panicked, extremely panicked. Even though the captain had told him not to panic, the moment he heard the news his head almost switched into full vibration mode.

Even Alice, listening at the side, had been so shocked by the captain's news that her head had fallen off – literally fallen off – and she still had not put it back on.

"You mean… every person in the ancient kingdom of Critt, from top to bottom, was copied from a part of my remains?" Goathead stared wide-eyed. "And it was the Abyssal Lord who did the copying?"

"Yes," Duncan said with a nod. "That also explains many of the historical puzzles that have always hung in front of the scholars about the ancient kingdom of Critt. For example, why that ancient kingdom almost left no systematic cultural records – because they were a short-lived people 'made' only for the Genesis Protocol and never had their own cultural system. Or for example, why the 'ruins' of the Critt people are found on islands that are not fit to live on at all, even islands covered by Visions. It is because every ancient Critt city was built as infrastructure for the Genesis Protocol. They were not meant to be settlements…"

Goathead's tone grew more and more complicated: "You know that's not what I'm worried about…"

"…Finding out all of a sudden that an ancient people are actually your own spawn is pretty shocking," Duncan said after a short pause, trying hard to

keep his face steady. “To be honest, I was pretty surprised too when I first heard it…”

At this point, Alice, who had not said much until now, suddenly spoke up: “But… but… but… Goat…”

“Put your head back on before you talk,” Duncan said helplessly, giving the doll a look. “Sitting there hugging your head is kind of scary.”

After her head fell off in fright, Alice had not put it back on. She had just been sitting beside Duncan, hugging her head and watching the drama with full attention. Now, reminded, she hurriedly reacted. With an “oh,” she quickly pressed her head back onto her neck, and at once her speech became smooth again: “But Goathead was already the main god of the elves, right? If you insist, all the elves in the world could be counted as his spawn. He should be able to accept this…”

“Easy for you to say.” Goathead swung his head around at once, as if resentment was about to leak out from his base. “I was asleep and half my body got taken away to be used as a culture medium, okay? And it would be one thing if it was only some ancient people. They even threw in a whole bunch of Enders! I always thought those mumbling ‘preachers’ were off. The moment they came on board they went straight down to kiss the deck. I’m telling you, if my material allowed it, I would have had goosebumps all over back then – and now I’m remembering those goosebumps again! What is this even, huh? I take a nap and wake up to this…”

Seeing Goathead slide quickly into full rambling mode, Duncan had to knock on the table twice to quiet his overexcited First Mate. Then he cleared his throat and broke the silence: “Ahem. The Enders were also normal Critt people once.”

Goathead froze for a moment, then reluctantly turned his neck. “That I do know… now I know… And even now, not all of them are that crazy… But

still…”

He kept saying “but” for a long time but never got to the point. After a long string of mutters, it all turned into a helpless sigh. His head drooped and he fell silent.

Alice could not help looking at Goathead a couple more times. Then she lifted her head and looked at Duncan, a little at a loss. After a moment she said hesitantly: “Captain… the First Mate doesn’t seem very happy.”

“It’s not really about being happy or unhappy. He just suddenly learned something very shocking. He needs to rest and then take some time to think calmly,” Duncan said with a light sigh as he rose from behind the chart table. “Let’s not bother him.”

“Oh,” Alice answered. She stood up from the chair and followed Duncan out of the captain’s cabin. But as she passed the edge of the enchanted sea chart table, she stopped again. After a moment of hesitation she reached out and patted Goathead on the head. “Have a good rest… You still have to teach me how to cook southern dishes later…”

Duncan listened from the side, the corner of his eye twitching despite himself. But this time he did not say anything. He only shook his head in silence and turned to walk out onto the deck.

The sea breeze was gentle, the broken waves rose and fell, and the distant sea glittered with light. It was still a fine day.

Duncan and Alice strolled onto the deck, and there they saw that Vanna had come up at some point too. She was leaning against the rail, facing the wind, staring into the distance as if lost in thought.

The sea breeze blowing from the border lifted Vanna’s silver-white hair. When she heard movement behind her, she turned and brushed back her long hair, a smile appearing on her face: “Captain, Alice.”

“I thought you would spend more time talking with Helena,” Duncan said with a nod as he walked over to the rail. “News this important is sure to shake everyone.”

“Yes, news this important,” Vanna said with a laugh, shaking her head. “Which is exactly why Her Eminence the Pope won’t have much time to chat with me from now on. She is probably still in a meeting with the other Eminences right now… Whether it’s the origin of the ancient kingdom of Critt, or the future of this world of ours they call the ‘Sanctuary World’, or those… already insane ‘end-survey teams’, any of it is enough to make a lot of people lose a lot of hair.”

“…After that, has Vision 004 shown any more signs of activity?” Duncan asked.

“No,” Vanna said, shaking her head. “After you left, we left a few watchers there. They reported that the assembly ground has shown no movement at all so far… In the past, even when the tomb itself did not appear, there would still be strange noises or shadows now and then in the assembly ground… It seems it’s just as you said. Vision 004 really has shut itself off from the outside world completely.”

“Just like the ‘Sun’ above our heads, that ‘tomb’ has reached the end of its life. Its mission is over,” Duncan said calmly. “The Gravekeeper warned me that even if messages come from the tomb again in the future, you must not answer them, and must never send people in again… If anything comes out of the tomb, even if the Gravekeeper himself walks out of there, you must not answer. You should pull back at once… By then it will no longer be the Vision 004 you know.”

“We know. Her Eminence the Pope has already warned all the Saints. From now on, Vision 004 will be a complete forbidden zone. Besides one rotating

team of ascetic monks stationed at the edge of the assembly ground to watch the situation, no one will go near the Nameless King's tomb again…"

Vanna spoke in a low voice, then slowly fell silent. After a few seconds she suddenly let out a sigh: "…Another thing has ended."

Yes, another thing had ended. But what did she mean? This very special "gathering"? The long "watch, summon, and Listening Rite" process aimed at the Nameless King's tomb that had formed over hundreds and thousands of years in the Four Gods Church? Or… one more legacy that the ancient Creators had left for this world?

Whatever it was, it had all come to an end.

"Did that Gravekeeper tell you anything about the 'Sun'?" Vanna suddenly asked after a brief silence. "Did he say how that 'Sun' was built, or… whether there is any way to repair it, even just to extend its…"

Duncan shook his head gently.

"He's just a guard," Duncan said. "A guard whose life and death were bound to that observation post when all the systems stopped and all the engineers and designers left, turned into part of the Vision. He already told me everything he knows. But the Sun…"

Duncan paused and looked out over the distant sea.

Vision 001 – the Sun – was moving slowly across the sky, like an old man at the end of his life, trudging toward his destination.

"The Sun is a vast project built together by the Crawling King and the entire Critt people. It's not something a guard could understand."

"…True," Vanna said with a self-mocking shake of her head. "I expected too much."

“Yes. But it’s fine, because that’s the problem I’m going to solve next,” Duncan said gently, glancing at Vanna. “We just have to go find that ‘designer’ from the Deep Sea era – starting with opening a door.”

As his words fell, a faint creaking sounded from deep within the Vanished’s hull. Right after that, Vanna felt a slight tremor under her feet, and then the half-transparent spirit-form sail slowly appeared on the mast –

The Vanished began slowly adjusting its posture and turning its bow. The huge, imposing ghost ship pointed its prow toward the distant sea – to the vast, hazy wall of mist that stood along the edge of the world.

…

At Lightwind Harbor, the solemn and holy great Storm Cathedral still lay quietly moored near the coastline. A priest in a blue and black robe hurried across the upper cloisters and arches of the Cathedral and almost ran to the door of the Pope’s prayer room: “Your Eminence! Your Eminence! That ship – the Vanished – has moved! Ten minutes ago it suddenly changed course and sped away from Lightwind Harbor!”

“I know,” Helena’s voice came from inside the prayer room, her magnetic tone carrying a calming power. “There’s no need to be so startled. It’s simply time.”

As she finished speaking, the dignified and elegant lady turned back and focused once more on the ritual brazier in front of her.

Part of her mind had sunk into the flames and still stayed within the channel built by the Psychic Communication.

“…the Vanished has already set sail. Vanna just sent me the news… Yes, the Tides has already set out with its escort ships. They will reach the agreed meeting point on time…

“Banster, what about that ‘dead-and-not-dead’ fleet of yours?”

A gloomy voice entered Helena’s mind: “It’s the Rest and the No Rest, Helena.”

“Fine, fine, it’s all the same… Where are they?”

“They’ve set out too. Don’t worry – we will all arrive on time.”

Chapter 702: Spirit Realm Convergence

The Vanished set out at last.

Over these past days, many people had watched its every move, including the four Cathedral arks, as well as the observers appointed by the city-states. Under so many watching eyes, that vast and solemn ghost ship, wreathed in fire and thick smoke, sped away from Lightwind Harbor at a speed that common sense could never accept, and in the blink of an eye vanished into the crack between the Spirit Realm and the Mortal Realm.

It appeared like a phantom and vanished like a phantom. Everything happened just as the legends described.

“We’re o~ff~!”

Shirley clutched the railing at the ship’s side and stared at the endless dark sea, swaying her body back and forth. She looked very pleased with herself.

The Vanished had already entered its Spirit Realm sailing state. The sea beyond the railing had turned into a sheet of pitch black. A sky of mixed black, white, and gray clouded over the whole world with a heavy, chaotic gloom. Far away, there were no more lighthouses, ships, or islands. Only all kinds of strange, shifting Shadows floated between sea and sky, as if they leaned over the horizon and looked down on the whole world.

Dog lay a short distance back from the railing, stretching his neck as far as he could. The chain around his neck pulled tight on Shirley’s arm while he

dug all four paws into the deck and shouted loudly: “Hey, stop swinging around! Careful you don’t fall!”

“Dog, since when did you get so timid?” Shirley simply sat down on the railing. While she tried to smooth her messy hair, she turned back with a grin and said: “You used to play by the edge of the deck all the time.”

“This is Spirit Realm depth!” Dog cried at once. “If you fall down here, you can’t get back up!”

Shirley ignored him. She just sat on the railing and kept grinning foolishly at the sea, until Duncan walked over, reached out, and gave her hair a rough rub: “You were never this excited when we set sail before. Why are you so happy to leave the city this time?”

“I got sick of Lightwind Harbor,” Shirley said, full of resentment. “There’s no good food in the city. The shops nearby are either bookstores or mechanical workshops. No good food, no fun places, and no good food…”

Duncan looked at her. It seemed Lightwind Harbor’s Elves cuisine had really left a shadow in her heart. He could not help reminding her: “There probably won’t be good food where we’re going either—in fact, we’ll be on the sea most of the time from now on.”

“That’s fine. The food on the ship is good, at least,” Shirley said happily. “And Nina won’t be dragging me around bookstores every single day. I’ll just treat it as getting some fresh air…”

“You get tired of the ship and want to go into the city, then you get tired of the city and want to go to sea…” Dog muttered, lying on the deck beside them. “All you think about is playing. Nina has almost gone through every bookstore in the whole city these days…”

Shirley waved her hand at once: “Ugh, Dog, don’t nag like some old aunt. My head hurts…”

Duncan did not answer. He only smiled and listened to Shirley and Dog bickering and complaining as always. Then, as if he sensed something, he suddenly raised his head and looked toward a certain spot on the nearby sea.

Almost at the same moment, a hazy Shadow rose up beside him. Agatha's figure appeared within that Shadow and reported softly: "The Radiant Star has arrived. It is searching for an entrance in the Mortal Realm."

Duncan nodded: "Mm. Go guide Lucy in."

Agatha's form faded away.

Only a moment later, Duncan saw large patches of Shadow suddenly spread above the dark sea near the Vanished.

The Shadows wove together like mist, rising and entwining. A huge, strange, and ornate ship slowly took shape within those shadows and thin fog. The Radiant Star sailed out from the mist. At first it was only a dim and blurry phantom, with only the stern looking solid and real. But as the Vanished drew closer, that hazy phantom suddenly became clear and solid in the blink of an eye, turning into an entity that could exist stably at this Spirit Realm depth.

The Radiant Star entered the Spirit Realm depth and began to sail side by side with the Vanished.

Shirley sat on the railing, craned her neck at the scene before her, and let out an exaggerated cry: "Woooow—"

Then she saw a small snow-white paper boat drifting up from the deck of the Radiant Star. The paper boat caught the wind, glided over the dark sea between the two ships, and finally landed steadily on the deck of the Vanished.

Lucretia, dressed in a black dress with black hair, stepped off the paper boat, bringing the clockwork Doll Lunie with her.

Alice, who was hanging strips of dried fish on the deck, noticed the movement at once. She happily ran over to welcome them: “Lunie! You’re here!”

The clockwork Doll walking beside Lucretia turned her head when she heard the voice. She also looked delighted and opened her arms as she stepped forward: “Alice!”

The two Dolls held hands and spun in circles on the deck. They had not really been apart for long, yet they were as happy as if they had been separated for years.

Alice pulled Lunie along and proudly showed her the freshly hung dried fish on the deck. Lunie clearly also had something she wanted to show off.

“Alice! Look at this, Mistress just made this for me…”

The clockwork Doll spoke happily as she reached up, cupped her own head, and then gently pulled upward. There was a soft popping sound.

Right in front of everyone on deck, she pulled her own head off.

Alice stared, dumbfounded. Because she usually did not think too deeply about things, she rarely looked this shocked. But she soon reacted and realized this was a new “function” her friend had mastered. A bright smile quickly appeared on her face: “Ah, you can do it too!”

As she spoke, she casually pulled her own head off her neck as well. The two Dolls each held their own heads and laughed together: “We… are… now… the same!”

Then the two Dolls started fooling around on the deck, giggling and playing.

Everyone else on the deck was completely stunned.

Duncan had been walking toward Lucretia, planning to ask about the Radiant Star's condition after entering the Spirit Realm. But halfway there, he was stopped cold by the sight of Alice and Lunie. To be honest, even in Subspace it would be hard to see something this bizarre.

He froze for several seconds before he finally reacted. Then he turned his head toward Lucretia, who was walking toward them: "What is going on here?"

Lucretia looked a bit dazed as well. While she walked, she could not help glancing back at the two Dolls wandering around with their heads in their hands. Hearing Duncan's question, her expression grew a little stiff: "I just did a small modification on Lunie… After that time when she pulled her head off and caused a malfunction, she kept bringing up how Alice's head joint could come off… She talked about it every few days. I got tired of hearing it, so I changed her joint for her…"

She stopped, hesitated, and looked at the two Dolls strolling along the deck carrying their heads. At last her expression cracked: "But I didn't expect this."

"…Forget it, as long as they're happy. Dolls… have their own ways of fun and social life," Duncan said. It took effort for him to put his shaken worldview back together. The corners of his mouth twitched as he finally pulled his gaze away from Alice and Lunie (which was not easy, since those two head-carrying Dolls were very eye-catching). He forced himself to put his attention back on Lucretia and the Radiant Star: "…Was the crossing smooth?"

Lucretia was still looking toward Lunie and Alice. Only when Duncan repeated the question did she jolt, quickly raise a hand to tap her forehead, and sort out her thoughts: "It was all right, just a bit chaotic…"

She finally shifted all her attention back, lifted her head, and glanced at the Radiant Star, which was now sailing automatically beside the Vanished. Her thoughts flowed more clearly as she spoke.

“This is the first time the Radiant Star has dived to such a ‘deep’ depth to sail… Normally, only her stern sits in the Spirit Realm. Being fully ‘submerged’ like this is a completely new experience, for both me and the ship.”

“This way we can go faster,” Duncan said with a smile. “The Vanished is already used to traveling at Spirit Realm depth. The White Oak and the Black Oak have both sailed alongside as escort ships before. At this depth, we need less than two days to catch up with that ‘returning ship’. And we don’t have to worry about anyone tracking us.”

Lucretia did not answer. She only lifted her head and looked at Duncan.

Father stood there, green flames rising and falling around him. He wore a confident and proud smile, just like in her memories.

After a while, she shook her head and asked: “What about the Church?”

“There will be two small fleets joining us, one from the Deep Sea Church and one from the Church of Death,” Duncan said casually. “The flagship from the Deep Sea Church is the Tidal and its escort group. The Church of Death is sending the Rest and the No Rest, a pair of sister ships, with their escorts. They say all of them are heavily armed warships.

“But what I care about more are the ‘professionals’ they’re bringing. When we face those strange things in the border sea, a scholar’s knowledge is sometimes more useful than firepower.”

“But a scholar’s expertise can also easily draw in even greater dangers…” Lucretia could not help reminding him. “Near the border, those restless Shadows are more eager to come out than anywhere else.”

Duncan raised an eyebrow: “Isn’t that even better?”

Lucretia’s expression went blank: “…”

“Anyway, let’s not talk about that. How is that ‘Saint’?” Duncan waved his hand and changed the subject. “Did you bring it this time?”

“Yes,” Lucretia answered at once. A faint pleased smile appeared on her face. “It is locked in the lowest containment hold of the Radiant Star right now. Don’t worry, its condition is good. I restored as much of its vitality as I could, as long as I was sure this ‘Saint’ could not escape. If you need it, I can bring it out at any time.”

“Not yet,” Duncan shook his head and looked toward the distant end of the chaotic dark sea. “We will use that ‘Saint’ when we find the ‘holy ground’ of those Annihilators.”

Chapter 703: Dolls Have Their Own Ways to Have Fun

This was a secret stretch of sea that did not appear on any official enchanted sea chart. It also lay far from any legal route.

The lights of the civilized world could no longer reach this sea, where a thin mist lay over the water. No deep-sea captain in their right mind would set foot here of their own will.

Ahead, the great wall of fog that encircled the entire world—the Veil—already stood in their path. And even though sunlight still shone on the sea, anyone sailing here would feel no comfort from that sunlight at all.

People had given this chilling place a name: the Border.

A ship that was almost torn to pieces, a ship that by any normal judgment should have sunk to the bottom long ago, was slowly sailing through the thin mist. It moved like a silent ghost toward the distant “fog wall” that rose like a sheer cliff.

ghostly green flame rose like silent phantoms, burning all around the broken ship. The half-transparent spirit form fire forced the ship, which should have been split into fragments, to stay together.

Half of its hull had been ripped open, leaving a terrifying gap. The huge and complex machinery inside lay exposed like the organs of some great beast, bathed in ghostly green flame. That eerie ghostfire spread outward from the

hull, flowing and spreading across the nearby sea. Wherever the flames flowed, the thin mist that filled the area slowly thinned and drifted away.

A column of flame surged up, and Duncan's figure appeared on the deck—half-transparent, in his spirit form.

Using the artificial beacon he had left on this ship, he had come here again. But this time, he did not teleport his whole "true body" here like last time. He only projected a phantom. Most of his attention still rested on the Vanished.

Since the fleets from all sides had not yet linked up, he wanted to come over first and check the situation here.

The towering fog wall finally stood before his eyes.

Duncan walked across the deck, stepped over the torn cracks left by the great explosion, and passed twisted, curled metal wreckage. He came to the bow and silently gazed at the magnificent "absolute view" ahead.

Before him stood a "wall" that reached from earth to sky. The thick fog had grown so dense it was almost solid, linking the heavens and the sea, standing in his field of vision like the end of the world.

From the top of the Veil, mighty streams of cloud poured down like waterfalls. They fell in silence onto the sea and turned into drifting mist, spreading across the entire border sea.

Before this grand barrier, the great ship he now stood on—built by cultists—seemed tiny. The Vanished would also be tiny. Even the Cathedral arks would be as small as dust.

"So this is the world's end…" Duncan stood quietly at the bow and murmured as if to himself: "I finally see it with my own eyes."

He remembered the “Border Collapse” he had witnessed not long after first arriving in this world, remembered how the wall of fog had suddenly collapsed in the middle of a normal sea. Back then, he had thought that scene as grand and awe-inspiring as anything he could imagine. Its crushing pressure still remained fresh in his heart even now.

But after truly standing here and seeing with his own eyes the endless Veil of the real border, he realized how small that “collapse” inside the Sanctuary World truly had been.

…But would this boundless, magnificent, true Border also have a day when it “collapsed”?

Duncan turned this thought over in his mind—a thought that would fill anyone else with fear and dread. He watched the distant scene for a while longer, then raised his hand and lightly waved through the air.

Flames coiled around his fingertips, tracing out an oval outline in the air. Inside the outline, a mirror-like surface appeared. A second later, Agatha’s figure surfaced in that mirror: “I am here.”

“What changes are there in the Spirit Realm here?” Duncan asked casually.

“Wait a moment. I’ll go down and look,” Agatha said. In the mirror, she nodded, and then her figure faded away.

Duncan waited patiently. After a short while, Agatha appeared again in the mirror—her hair now a bit messy.

“The Spirit Realm is darker and more chaotic here. Shapeless Shadows sweep across the sea. Compared to ‘inside the civilized world’, those Shadows feel far less friendly,” Agatha reported while smoothing her hair. She paused, then added: “…Very unfriendly, actually. Almost violent.”

“You got beaten up?” Duncan frowned, sounding a little worried.

“I beat up everything that came close,” Agatha said, rolling her shoulders. She looked almost cheerful.

After putting down the heavy memories of the Gatekeeper and spending more time on the Vanished, she had grown used to the crew’s… gang-like mood. “They weren’t hard to deal with, just stranger in shape. Also…”

“Also?”

“There is also a ‘Veil’ in the Spirit Realm,” Agatha said. She raised a hand and pointed toward the great wall of the Veil in the distance. “It stands there like a dark reflection of this Veil, and it looks… even more dangerous and strange. Many shapeless forms rise and shift inside that black Veil. I don’t have a good feeling about it.”

Duncan frowned slightly as he listened.

“So the plan of ‘diving’ beneath the Eternal Veil from Spirit Realm depth won’t work,” he said thoughtfully. “It seems this ‘border’ surrounds the whole world on all levels. There is no safe shortcut…”

“That is more or less what we expected,” Agatha nodded. “If our world is a ‘Sanctuary World’, then the walls of this Sanctuary World must be tight enough. Only then can we have a safe place to live in the chaos after worlds collide.”

She paused to think, then went on: “In the World Model Mr. Morris has been refining, the Veil at the border should block both the Mortal Realm and the Spirit Realm. It may even reach down into the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea.

“And it doesn’t just seal us off in space. From the point of view of time, there should also be something like an ‘Eternal Veil’ to make sure the entire Sanctuary World is complete…”

“A border in the dimension of time…” Duncan said. “In Vision 004, that Gravekeeper also spoke to me about it.” He shook his head. “Mr. Morris must have taken his revelation from there too.”

“Yes. He has been trying to build a World Model that can explain the whole Boundless Sea, even the whole age of the Deep Sea,” Agatha said gently, with a hint of respect in her voice. “The truths we recently found deep in the Nameless One’s dream, and the information you just brought back from the Nameless King’s tomb, have helped him make great progress lately.

“He has started trying to explain the world we live in using both time and space. He is the only scholar I know who has reached this step.”

“Strictly speaking, he is the only scholar who has reached this step and is still alive,” Duncan said with feeling. “Recently his research has been causing… extra commotion on the ship. It’s the same when Nina reads.”

“Scholars always end up wrestling with the knowledge they study,” Agatha said, clearly used to this. “Miss Nina’s situation is much better now. She has learned to stay calm when things jump out of her books…

“That might be related to the time she accidentally burned the design drawing she had spent three days and three nights working on.”

Hearing this, the corner of Duncan’s mouth twitched.

Even though he had lived in this world for quite some time now, every time he heard about such bizarre events, he still could not help wanting to complain.

But in any case, the noise Nina and Morris caused while wrestling with knowledge was still better than the two Dolls on the ship playing their “head-swapping game” right now.

In the captain’s cabin of the Vanished, Duncan blinked and looked up helplessly as he spoke with Lucretia about what they had learned of the

Border.

A figure in a black-and-white maid dress staggered into the cabin. The large clockwork key on her back turned with a constant clicking sound. When she saw Duncan in the room, a slow smile spread across her face: “Cap… tain… what… are we hav… having for din… ner?”

Duncan held it in for two seconds before he finally could not stand it: “Alice, why is your head on Lunie’s body?”

Alice’s face showed sudden surprise: “Ah, how… did you… find… find out?”

“I’m not blind! And I’m not stupid!” Duncan slapped a hand to his forehead. Right after that, he heard heavy thumping sounds outside the captain’s cabin, as if someone was walking into the wall again and again.

He rose from behind the enchanted sea chart table, walked to the doorway, and saw Alice’s body outside—now wearing Lunie’s head—banging into the wall over and over. As the body walked, Lunie’s head kept calling out: “You hit it, you hit it—move a bit left… hey, left, you got it backwards! On your side that’s right! Ah, you hit it again… more to the left—ah, crash—Old Master?”

Duncan stared with a blank face at Lunie’s head, which had frozen in shock. A moment later, Lucretia also stepped out behind him, her expression just as stiff.

The two of them stood there together, faces wooden, watching the Lunie+Alice combined body. They watched as Alice’s body kept walking forward and bumped straight into the door frame with another thud.

“Stop walking!” Lunie’s head shouted quickly. “Old Master and Mistress are out here!”

Right after she shouted that, she unconsciously moved her own body inside the cabin toward the door as well, and there was a loud thump from behind them.

Duncan lowered his head and saw a silver-haired head roll to his feet. Alice blinked up at him with innocent eyes: “Cap… tain… save… save… save me…”

At the same time, the Lunie+Alice combination body outside also stepped into thin air, missed its footing, and fell over beside the hem of Lucretia’s dress. Lunie’s head bounced off the body, hit the floor with a thud, and rolled while crying out in a panic: “Mistress! I fell off too!!”

For a moment, the scene was beyond any words.

Duncan’s mind spun for a long time as he tried to sort out the positions of these two Dolls. At last he could not hold back anymore and shouted in unison with Lucretia: “You two switch back!”

Chapter 704: Doll and Doll and Doll

In the dining room on the upper deck, Duncan and Lucretia sat side by side, both with stiff faces. The two head?swapping troublemakers, who had just put their heads back on, sat in the chairs across from them. Lunie looked a little nervous and uneasy, while Alice wore her usual bright smile and even looked as if she had not played enough.

After holding it in for a few seconds, Duncan finally spoke first: “Was it fun?”

Lunie immediately lowered her head and fidgeted with her fingers, looking awkward. Alice, however, nodded happily: “It was fun, Captain! You have no idea, it turns out our connector sizes are exactly the same…”

Duncan’s eyelid twitched. Then he noticed Lunie’s little habit of picking at her fingers. For some reason, the gesture felt familiar. After wondering about it for a moment, he looked thoughtfully at the Sea Witch beside him: “When you were little and did something wrong, didn’t you also like to pick at your fingers?”

“Uh… that was when I was very young…” Lucretia had not expected the topic to suddenly fall on her. She froze for a moment. Then her expression turned a little odd. “You… you still remember that?”

“…I don’t remember, but it still feels familiar,” Duncan shook his head lightly, then cleared his throat twice and turned his gaze back to the two dolls. “Whose idea was it first?”

This time the two dolls finally answered in unison: “Shirley!”

Duncan: “…?”

A moment later, Duncan and Lucretia still sat on the dining room bench with stern faces. But this time, sitting across from them, besides the two head?swapping troublemakers, there was also Shirley.

Dog lay on the floor next to Shirley, hugging his own head with his paws while muttering under his breath: “Don’t look at me, this has nothing to do with me, I tried to talk them out of it, I just couldn’t stop them…”

Duncan glanced at the grumbling Dog, then looked at Shirley. He remembered how she had once tricked Alice into pouring superglue down her own neck, and could not help sighing in his heart. He really did have to keep a closer eye on this girl who feared the world might be too peaceful…

“Why are you giving them bad ideas just because you’re bored?” Duncan sighed and looked helplessly at Shirley. “We are sailing in the Spirit Realm. This is not like being on land. If they really got dizzy and fell into the sea, would you be the one responsible for fishing them out?”

Shirley had already drawn in her neck in that well?practiced pose for accepting criticism. But when she heard the captain’s words, her eyes suddenly lit up: “So that means we can play like this on land?!”

Duncan: “…Do you want to listen to what you’re saying?”

Shirley gave an awkward little laugh, but then her smile turned sly. She leaned forward, grinning, and muttered: “You can’t blame me for this, Captain. Think about it, when you saw the two of them, didn’t you have the same thought? Two dolls who can take their heads off, using the same kind of joints. In Old Gentleman’s words… it’s the spirit of exploration, right? You really don’t want to try it…?”

In the ears of someone with a strong curiosity, Shirley's words were like a tempting whisper from Subspace itself. Duncan's eyebrow twitched. He was just about to speak when he heard a barely audible mutter beside him: "It does kind of make sense…"

Duncan's expression turned a little strange. He turned his head toward the source of the mutter. Lucretia looked up, a bit embarrassed, and when she realized what she had said, she hurried to add: "Of course this kind of behavior is not something we should encourage. Any experiment has to be built on caution and safety…"

Duncan had to work hard to keep his face under control. He kept a calm, serious look and pretended to ignore Lucretia's mutter. Then he sighed and looked at the two head?swapping troublemakers across from him: "Don't play like that again. At least, don't do it on the ship. It's not safe. Remember?"

"Okay, got it, Captain!" "Yes, Old Master."

"Go back to your room and stay there. If you really don't want to do your homework, then read a book for a while, even a picture book," Duncan waved a hand at Shirley. "We are about to leave the Spirit Realm and then enter the eternal Veil. Before that, stop running around making trouble everywhere."

Shirley lowered her head and answered obediently: "Oh, okay, Captain…"

The dining room finally grew quiet. Shirley left with Dog, while Alice dragged Lunie to a corner of the room. The two whispered about who? knew?what—at least this time each of them was carrying her own head.

Duncan glanced in the directions they had gone, shook his head, and sighed. But for some reason, he felt a bit relaxed and cheerful inside.

It seemed that ever since the Lightwind Harbor incident, it had been a long time since he had been able to breathe out like this.

But Lucretia's slightly uneasy voice came from beside him: "Are you… angry?"

Duncan did not look back: "Why do you say that?"

"…We are about to head to the border to investigate the cultists' holy land. It's a dangerous and serious task. Yet Lunie chose this time to cause you trouble…"

She had only spoken halfway when Duncan suddenly interrupted her: "So that's what you were like as a child?"

Lucretia did not react for a moment: "…Hm?"

"Lunie," Duncan raised his hand and pointed at the clockwork doll in the distance who was whispering with Alice and now and then showing a happy smile. "Is that what you were like as a child? I mean, in terms of personality."

Lucretia did not speak for a while. She only pressed her lips together. After a good moment, she finally spoke softly: "…Lunie was the first doll I made. I sealed in her body some parts of my soul that tend to make me make mistakes. Most of the time, those sealed fragments do not affect her operation. But sometimes, they make her act in rather odd ways."

"So most of the time Lunie looks calm and reliable. But when she is with Alice, she becomes lively?"

"…Yes. It seems it will make her make mistakes—at least it raises the chance of it."

Duncan looked back at Lucretia: "Even this level of 'mistake' counts as a problem?"

Lucretia was silent for a few seconds, then answered softly: “On the border, a mistake can easily get you killed.”

Duncan did not speak for a while. He only watched the two dolls in the distance with a thoughtful gaze as they chatted happily about something. After a while, he spoke in a calm tone: “When you are by my side, you are allowed to make mistakes.”

For a moment Lucretia seemed a little dazed. She opened her mouth as if she wanted to say something, but in the end said nothing. Her gaze only followed Father’s gaze in that direction:

Alice seemed to be telling Lunie about some fun things on the ship, or at least things she thought were fun, and Lunie listened with great interest. Alice rarely chatted so happily with anyone other than the captain, and Lunie—who served as the first mate on the Radiant Star and the Sea Witch’s servant—had probably never met a kindred spirit like Alice whom she could talk with this way.

The two dolls seemed to be getting along very well.

Just then, Duncan seemed to suddenly remember something: “Right, there’s something I’ve been putting off…”

As he spoke, he waved casually in midair. AI, who had been happily devouring fries at a nearby table, vanished on the spot. The next second, a ring of eerie, spinning green flame appeared beside Duncan. He reached into the ring of fire and fished something out, then set it down on the table in front of him.

Lucretia looked at the object in surprise. It was an elegant wooden box about seventy centimeters long. Aside from its fine, old?fashioned craftsmanship, it did not seem special.

But slowly, she felt from the wooden box a long?lost sense of… familiarity and closeness.

“This is Nilu.” Duncan opened the wooden box, and a delicate one?third? scale doll appeared in front of Lucretia. “I said a long time ago that I would give her to you, but too many things have been happening and it got delayed. Now that I saw Alice and Lunie together… take her. Let their ‘sister’ join them again.”

Lucretia’s expression turned a little strange. She took the box and carefully lifted the one?third?scale doll named “Nilu” out of it. She set the doll on the table, letting her sit leaning against the box, while her thoughts slowly drifted far away—

In that distant afternoon, with the clear sound of wind chimes ringing, she had walked hand in hand with her brother into that doll shop. Lunie and Nilu had sat quietly in the shop window. Warm sunlight shone on their delicate hair and dresses like a faint veil.

Back then, she could only take one of them away.

But that was already one of the few warm memories of her childhood that she still had. In those warm days, the Sun had still been something that was sure to rise into the sky again the next morning.

The Witch felt a little dazed, and in that daze, the little doll sitting on the table and leaning against the box slowly turned her head and showed her an empty smile.

Lucretia woke from her trance and saw that the little doll was still sitting quietly on the table, her head tilted obediently to the side. The shell without a soul inside was hollow and empty.

She reached out and tapped her finger on the doll’s forehead: “Go back to sleep.”

The doll’s body suddenly shook, as if a brief life had been poured into her. Then she climbed to her feet stiffly and stumbled into the elegant wooden box. She grabbed the lid beside her and tried hard to pull it down.

But she was too weak.

Duncan reached out and gave it a push, helping the doll close the lid.

“Thank you.” A tiny voice came from inside the box, then fell silent again.

“That was remarkable.” Duncan looked up and spoke to Lucretia with some surprise.

“We are entering the border now. Many things are becoming active,” Lucretia said. “If we inject souls into some things ahead of time, we can stop some uninvited guests from ‘sneaking aboard’. Many years ago, Lunie ‘woke up’ for the first time in just this way.”

“…It’s also time to rise up and get some air.” Duncan nodded. As he spoke, he slowly rose from behind the table.

As he moved, the Vanished began to rise slowly from the depths of the Spirit Realm. Outside the dining room portholes, the daylight was growing brighter.

The Shadows that lurked in the Spirit Realm slowly faded away from all directions.

Chapter 705: The Eerie Atmosphere at the Border

As the Shadows in the Spirit Realm quickly retreated from around the Vanished, the sea that had been pitch?black slowly returned to its usual blue. Daylight from the Mortal Realm and the drifting mist around the ships spread to cover the whole ocean.

Nina ran out from her room onto the deck and quickly spotted the strange, almost shattered great ship not far ahead of the Vanished, wrapped in eerie green flame.

That ship had been destroyed by a massive explosion and was now driven only by spirit form fire. It was slowly slowing down, yet still sailing forward. In the direction its bow pointed lay the “border” that had once appeared in her textbooks, but that she was seeing for the first time today.

A majestic wall of thick fog rose from sea to sky. Cloud?like mist poured down from the top of the giant wall like a waterfall, turning into thin haze that filled the whole sea region. In front of it, all things seemed small. Even though Nina had already seen many unbelievable sights while following the Vanished, she still could not help widening her eyes and letting out a long shout: “Waaah—”

Shirley also ran out at this time. She grabbed the rail at the ship’s side and looked into the distance, shouting together with Nina: “Waaah—”

Her voice had barely fallen when Dog’s voice floated out from the Shadows: “This is why I tell you to read more. If your vocabulary were

even a little bigger, you wouldn’t only be able to say ‘waaah’ after seeing a Veil this grand at the border…”

Shirley’s eyes widened: “Didn’t Nina also go ‘waaah’? Why aren’t you talking about her?”

Dog jumped out from the Shadows, shaking his head as he muttered: “Nina says ‘waaah’ because she feels the word fits here. You say ‘waaah’ because it’s the only word you know. The two of you are not the same…”

Hearing Dog’s nagging, Shirley puffed out her cheeks in protest and argued loudly: “I… I have lots of words! I have so many interjections. It’s just that the captain and Morris, Old Gentleman, never let me use them! If I really talked the way I wanted, I…”

But Dog was no longer paying attention to her. This Abyssal Hound with its fierce shape had become even more cautious after reaching the border. He looked around, as if sensing the breaths coming from other dimensions. After a moment, he grumbled: “…This place isn’t like the safe sea zones. There are unstable auras everywhere. We’re clearly in the Mortal Realm, yet I can faintly smell the scent of the Spirit Realm…”

“This is the border, and this is only the smallest part of its countless strange and dangerous traits.” As a swirl of colorful paper scraps spun through the air, Lucretia’s voice came. “Here, the boundary of the ‘Mortal Realm’ becomes blurred. All those ‘things’ that are suppressed in the safe sea zones become active. Machines are much more likely to go mad. Books will draw more, and more dangerous, watchers. Many things on the ship will find it easy to come alive. And at certain times, especially when the ship accidentally overlaps with some invisible ‘field’, these dangers will multiply.”

She strolled to the edge of the deck and looked at the distant wall of thick fog. Lost in thought and memory, she went on softly—

“So almost no sane explorer comes to the border to ‘try their luck’… There is no honor or wealth here. There is only a cold, uncanny environment and a dangerous, terrible fate. The very few madmen who dare to set foot here have worked out certain ‘rules of conduct’ that exist only at the border. For example, do not carry any idol or portrait that has human features on the ship. Do not shout loudly in the fog. Do not stand in front of a mirror for too long, and so on…”

“But these rules and taboos can only lower the risk to a point. Seasoned explorers still vanish in the mists near the border. They forget where they are when the fog rises. They push open doors in the cabins that do not exist. They may even, in a daze, believe they have already finished a dangerous, long exploration of the border and safely returned to the city?state where they started. Their tight nerves relax. They finally breathe out and step onto the solid planks of the pier—only to walk straight into the thick fog of the border, leaving behind an empty ghost ship drifting on the sea.”

As the Sea Witch spoke of these eerie, terrifying things, Shirley’s eyes grew wider and wider until she shivered without thinking: “I… oh crap… that sounds kind of scary…”

“Yes, it is very scary. So under normal conditions, people like you, who have no experience exploring the border, should never come near these waters. But you still don’t need to worry, because this is the Vanished, and you are members of the Vanished Fleet.”

Lucretia smiled faintly, gazing out at the sea as she spoke slowly.

“Father and this ship… are no longer the way I remember them. With the Vanished as it is now, I believe that even if some ‘thing’ really slipped onto the ship and opened your cabin door, it would politely apologize and even close the door on its way out…”

As soon as she finished speaking, a voice suddenly came from the side: “Normally, they don’t get the chance to close the door or apologize.”

Lucretia turned her head and saw that Duncan had come up onto the deck at some point.

“Vanna just received a psychic communication. The Deep Sea Church’s Tide has already reached these waters and will appear soon. Two main ships of the Death Church are also nearby. They’re sending out small scout boats to first check the situation in the surrounding sea.”

Lucretia nodded: “That’s good. We need to understand what’s going on around here. In this area, the Church fleets that patrol the border all year round are a bit more professional than we are.”

Duncan grunted in reply and said nothing more. He only guided the Vanished to slowly draw closer to the “guide” ship ahead. Beside the Vanished, the Radiant Star had also shed its Spirit Realm state and was sailing along at an easy pace.

A dozen minutes later, the Vanished and the Radiant Star reached the area near the broken great ship and kept a slow, steady cruise.

Perhaps because they were closer to the Veil, the mist on the sea grew thicker than before. Layer upon layer of fog drifted in all directions like flowing curtains. Even the eerie green flame spilling from around the Vanished could not fully drive the mist away.

On Duncan’s command, the three ships stopped before the fog could get even thicker.

“We’ll move on after we rendezvous,” Duncan said on the foredeck of the Vanished as he looked at the fog?shrouded sea in the distance. “Light the beacon first.”

As he spoke, he raised his hand and pointed at the guide vessel in the very front.

With a snap of his fingers, the eerie green flame burning on that great ship suddenly flared brighter. The roaring spirit flame swelled and rose at once, bursting upward and sending out a radiance bright enough to pierce the fog!

A “lighthouse” made entirely of spirit flame rose up in the fog?covered border sea. The light pouring from the fire shone fiercely over the whole area. Under that glow, on the sea around the three ships, the mist finally showed signs of thinning and their visibility improved a little.

Vanna and Morris came up onto the deck as well. Morris was curiously studying the sea near the rail. He saw that the color of the water seemed a bit deeper than it was beyond the thick fog. The dark blue sea looked fairly calm, only with slight ripples in the breeze. But those ripples looked strange. They were slow and sticky, as if… the whole sea were a layer of thick, smooth oil with no detail on its surface.

Frowning, Vanna fixed her gaze on this stretch of sea that gave off such a strong sense of strangeness and doubt. After hesitating for a moment, she took a small wooden charm amulet from her clothes—a wave?shaped charm amulet carved from Sea-Breath Wood—and threw it into the sea.

The charm amulet, which stood for the Storm Goddess’s faith and blessing, landed on the slow, sticky surface of the sea. It bounced once as if it had fallen on solid ground. No ripple spread out, and it did not sink into the water.

It simply stayed there, resting on that slow, sticky “surface” for several seconds. Then it was suddenly dyed a dark blue by the surrounding water and quietly “melted” into the sea.

Vanna stared in some shock at this scene that did not fit her experience.

But in her ears, the gentle sound of waves still rose as always.

Although the process looked very strange, the power of Goddess Gamona still descended as usual. Even in this abnormal sea region, the Storm Goddess's blessing could still take effect.

It even seemed… to have taken effect a little faster?

Just then, Vanna seemed to suddenly sense something else. She raised her head and looked toward the distant, mist?shrouded sea.

Almost as soon as she looked up, a long, clear horn blast suddenly broke the calm of the border sea. Right after that, a hazy light appeared deep within the thick fog—and behind that light, the huge shape of a ship slowly emerged.

The gentle sound of waves rose again. Through Psychic Resonance, she confirmed the message coming from her Church comrades. At the same time, the huge ship in the distance began to slow down at a set distance, and several smaller escort ships appeared one after another around its outline.

Through the drifting mist, the ships that had come to rendezvous and the Vanished and the Radiant Star, which had arrived earlier, carefully confirmed each other's identities. In the border sea, this was a very important step.

And this kind of identity "confirmation" would continue throughout the whole operation. They would have to do it again at set intervals.

After all, in the thick fog of the border, you could not always be sure that the figure beside you this second was still the person you knew a second ago.

"It's the Deep Sea Church's Tide and its escort group," Vanna reported quickly as she came to Duncan's side. "We've confirmed it through Psychic Resonance."

Duncan nodded: “Good. Allow them to come closer. Let them enter the area lit by the spirit flame.”

Chapter 706:

In the fog that filled the whole sea, hanging like endless gauze, the Tide and her two escort ships from the Deep Sea Church began to enter the region illuminated by the spirit flame, the Sacred beacon Torch. Their hulls gradually grew clear in the mist. The outlines that had been trembling and wavering under the influence of the border environment also became steadier in the firelight.

For the sailors aboard the Tide, the changes were even more obvious. The ghostly green flame soaring into the sky was like a lighthouse that brought order. The eternal mist of the border sea actually receded like a sacred miracle around that lighthouse. As they drew closer to the flame, the faint noise and whispering in the surroundings weakened as well. None of this was something these sailors, who had patrolled near the eternal Veil for years, had ever experienced.

On the foredeck of the Vanished, Vanna slightly furrowed her brow and tilted her head in a Listening Rite, as if she were picking out distant sounds from the wind. Then she nodded to Duncan: “Commander Sandra of the Tide sends you his greetings and respects. He is asking about the next step.”

Duncan nodded: “We wait for the Rest and the No Rest to arrive. Then we enter the thick fog. Make sure we do not leave the range lit by the flame lighthouse.”

Vanna immediately passed the captain’s orders to her fellow church members. Duncan, meanwhile, was quite interested in this “psychic communication” of hers that let her contact nearby Deep Sea believers

through meditation and prayer. After watching with curiosity for a while, he suddenly seemed to remember something else: “Speaking of which… should we really install a radio set on the Vanished?”

“If you want to use it in safe waters, that’s fine. But if you want to use it on the border… then it won’t be reliable,” Vanna answered very seriously. “In the border sea, the chance of machines going mad is very high. Only machines like steam cores, which have strong protection, can still run stably. Everything else will have problems more or less, and radio is the most likely of all to go wrong.”

As Vanna finished, Lucretia spoke up beside her: “A running radio set can easily pick up ‘voices’ from unknown sources. Those voices will corrupt people’s minds. Some things can even crawl along the radio into the Mortal Realm and quietly corrupt any device that isn’t under steam’s protection. So as a rule, ships entering the border sea shut down their radios, and they even cut the internal phones on board.”

“Something can crawl along the radio into the Mortal Realm?” Duncan raised his eyebrows. He seemed to find this rather… interesting. “So the patrol ships on the border basically have to rely on Vanna’s kind of ‘psychic communication’ to stay in contact?”

“Psychic Resonance is a sacred miracle granted by the God,” Vanna lowered her head slightly and traced the sigil of the storm goddess Gamona on her chest. “Like the steam-blessed boilers, the words sent out through Psychic Resonance are under divine blessing. In this chaotic border sea, they can avoid being corrupted and twisted by outside forces. Of course, this doesn’t mean absolute safety. Psychic communication can still be interfered with and corrupted. In this endless fog, there is no such thing as one hundred percent safety.”

“I see…” Duncan nodded thoughtfully. Just as when he first set foot on the city-states, he absorbed this new knowledge about the border with keen curiosity and a strong desire to understand it. Then he turned his head and casually asked toward what looked like empty air: “What about you, Agatha? Is the ‘psychic communication’ between you, the Rest, and the No Rest the same as Vanna’s? As a ‘shadow’, is there any difference between the psychic communication you use to contact other death priests and the usual kind?”

Agatha’s hazy figure appeared, floating above the deck, and her slightly airy voice came from the air: “As far as I can feel, there is no real difference. Even after becoming like this, I can still feel Bartok’s divine blessing just as in my ‘memories’, and through it I can still hear the voices of my brothers and sisters in the Church. In fact… after coming here, I feel those voices are even clearer than in my ‘memories’. It’s quite unbelievable.”

The “memories” Agatha spoke of clearly referred to her “life as a Gatekeeper”. That life was false, but those memories were a perfect copy of the real Agatha’s. The judgment she made from them naturally had great reference value.

The “replicant Agatha” who existed as a shadow actually felt the voices clearer than in her memories when she listened to psychic communication in the border sea?

This counterintuitive detail made Duncan fall into thought. He had always believed that, in anything involving divine magic and sacred miracles, the replicant Agatha was weaker than her true self left behind in Frostholm. Yet here, in the border sea, the situation… did not seem to match his expectations.

In the end… what were the Four Gods Church's priests actually handling when they used this power called "Psychic Resonance" to build their web of psychic communication?

Duncan drifted into these thoughts without meaning to, but his thinking was soon interrupted.

"They're here," Agatha's voice came suddenly from the shadow. "The Rest and the No Rest are drawing near."

A piercing whistle rolled out of the depths of the fog. Two black ironclads with towering bridges, small cathedrals rising at their sterns, and heavy main guns on their bows and flanks slowly emerged from the mist. Four small escort ships surfaced with the swell of the fog around them.

The bright spirit flame rising from the Guide Vessel lit up their blurred silhouettes. In response, the two black ironclads blew their whistles again in greeting and flashed a series of light signals.

"Commander Polly of the Rest and Commander Orlando of the No Rest send you their greetings and respects," Agatha said, nodding slightly to Duncan. "They have already sent out scout boats to make a rough check of the surrounding sea. They found no trace of Annihilator activity and no small islands suitable as temporary footholds or lookout posts. But inside the Veil, the scout boats did briefly pick up some unusual noise. We can be sure there is indeed 'something' in that direction."

As he listened to Agatha's report, Duncan's expression grew more and more serious. Then he exhaled softly and slowly calmed himself.

"Let's move out. And I'll say it again: do not leave the area lit by the spirit flame."

The shattered Guide Vessel began to pick up speed again. With it at their head, the "joint fleet" formed by the Deep Sea Church, the Death Church,

and the so-called Vanished Fleet finally sailed toward the eternal Veil and slowly entered the depths of the endless fog.

The sky-filling clouds and mist pressed in like a wall, and at some point turned into layered curtains surrounding the fleet. The Sun was left behind them. sunlight faded from sight. As the fog grew thicker, a kind of chaotic but not completely dark “sky-glow” became the dominant color of this sea within the mist.

About thirty minutes after they crossed the boundary of the Veil, the fog began to “gather” in a clear way and grew denser and denser. It started to take on a… viscous, almost textured form, like chunks of something solid floating unevenly in every corner of their vision.

Dim outlines flashed inside those clumps of condensed fog, as if something were watching this fleet that had suddenly barged into the border sea, quietly observing these uninvited guests.

The deck gradually fell quiet. Even Shirley, who was normally always chattering, seemed to sense the change in the air. She closed her mouth, staring at the “clumps” of fog that flowed past the ship’s side like living things and at the faint shapes in the mist.

“This… this doesn’t look like the ‘fog’ I know at all…” Dog muttered quietly. “It’s not the same as what we saw outside the Veil either…”

“Once you enter the Veil, the texture of the fog turns into this,” Lucretia said. She stood by the rail and reached out, her fingertips gently brushing the streams of fog pouring past like rivers in the air. “It’s as if the order between real and unreal has broken down. The diffuse mist starts to gather into clumps, as if something with a mind of its own is out there, pulling the fog together.”

“But in fact, there is nothing inside them. The centers of these clumps are empty. Don’t trust any ‘solid’ thing you see in the fog too easily. Unless it shows clear signs of activity, it’s best to treat everything as a phantom or your own imagination.”

“Hey, is it really okay to just stick your hand in there like that?” Shirley couldn’t help yelling when she saw Lucretia’s movements. “This fog looks super shady!”

“The fog is dangerous, but that doesn’t mean it’s some kind of corrosive poison,” Lucretia glanced at Shirley and shook her head. “If that were the case, you would have died the moment we entered the Veil. With enough experience and the right methods, the area within six nautical miles of the border counts as a ‘relatively safe zone’… Of course, no matter how careful you are, plenty of people have still died in this so-called ‘relatively safe zone’.”

While listening to Lucretia and Shirley talk, Duncan stayed silent. He simply stood at the bow, watching the streams of fog as they merged and split nearby, his expression thoughtful.

Lucretia noticed Duncan’s silence.

“Dad, did something come to mind?”

Duncan blinked. After a moment’s hesitation, he finally muttered softly: “It looks very familiar.”

“Familiar?” Lucretia echoed.

Duncan grunted in reply, but his gaze did not leave the amorphous clumps drifting all around. He stared at the faint shapes inside the fog, the muddy sky-glow above, and the strange textures that sometimes showed themselves where the clouds flowed. His brow furrowed deeper and deeper…

Chapter 707:

The fleet moved at low speed through the condensed, lingering fog. Their hazy silhouettes looked at one another, like a cluster of massive ghosts rising and falling in a sea of mist.

Inside the eternal Veil, the power of the fog far surpassed that outside the barrier. As the fleet pushed onward, the surrounding mist grew harder and harder to disperse. Even with the blazing spirit flame lighthouse shining over the entire formation, thin fog still kept drifting in from the edges of the sea, wrapping around every ship and flowing across the decks. The omnipresent mist even began to seep into the cabins, drifting around the sailors.

Commander Sandra of the Tide stood at the command station in the ship's bridge, frowning as he watched the thin fog slowly curling around them.

He was a tall man with slightly dark skin and striking short hair the color of white gold. The storm tattoo on the left side of his face showed that he had once been an ascetic, who had completed all his vows and thus earned promotion and divine blessing. That was how he became a respected border commander. Now, however, this border commander's expression did not look hopeful.

"How far have we gone?"

Sandra turned his head and suddenly asked the technical Father beside him.

"We are closing in on the six-nautical-mile boundary—only the last mile left," answered the Father, whose gray hair stuck out beneath a robe

embroidered with thunder and gear emblems. “Our speed is low, but even at this pace we will soon reach that ‘limit’.”

Sandra nodded, but his frown deepened.

Six nautical miles… and that lighthouse still showed no sign of stopping. It was still leading the fleet slowly toward the deeper fog, which meant that so-called “holy ground” lay farther inside. But if they went on like this, the fleet would soon cross that “forbidden line”.

Beyond six nautical miles lay the absolute limit of civilization’s light. Once they crossed it, the last trace of order on the Boundless Sea would vanish, even if the Saint and the Pope came in person.

The great Cathedral of Storms had ordered the Tide to fully cooperate with the Vanished’s operation here, but that did not include crossing the “six? nautical?mile boundary”.

Sandra looked toward the depths of the mist ahead, his brow still furrowed.

Those Annihilators still had not appeared… which also made no sense.

With such a narrow “safe sea” along the border, a fleet this large was hard to hide—especially with that blazing flame lighthouse standing in the fog. If the cultists really were hiding nearby, they would have noticed this formidable joint fleet long ago. Whether they chose to meet them head-on or set an ambush, this sea should not be so “quiet”. It was so quiet it was as if… there were no cultists here at all.

Had they all escaped already?

A bold thought flashed through Sandra’s mind, and he sank into deeper reflection.

Those cultists had probably known their secret was exposed long ago. After their ship of “sacrificial rites”, soaked in blood and evil, was captured by

Captain Duncan, they truly had enough time to flee this place. But the key question was…

Would a bunch of fanatical cultists really abandon their “holy ground” out of fear?

Some of them might run for their lives. But based on Sandra’s many years of dealing with cultists, more of those crazed heretics would definitely stay behind, squeezing every vile and terrifying trick they had to fight the Churches to the death. Those madmen whose minds were completely rotted by blasphemous thoughts had never been stingy about sacrificing their own lives for their “faith”.

Tiny scraps of noise drifted into Sandra’s ears, like sharp but faint tinnitus. Along with the ringing came trembling shadows at the edges of his vision.

Sandra frowned, glancing down at the rail in front of him. Under the handrail, the metal was shining with iridescent colors. Oily “droplets” were forming in those colors and dripping one by one onto the deck.

Illusions—hallucinations and phantom sounds common in the border sea. But at the “depth” where the fleet now sailed, they were actually quite mild.

That, he knew, was thanks to the power of the giant flame lighthouse.

“Have the cathedrals on board light the incense and ring the prayer bells. Increase pressure in the steam pipes,” Sandra said, lifting his head to glance at the ghostly green flame in the distance. “Remind the other ships to watch their crews’ mental state.”

…

Commander Polly of the Rest looked down at her right hand in its black long glove. She slowly clenched her fist. When she opened it again, the few vague eyeballs that had appeared in her palm without warning were gone.

This priestess with the dark gold curls raised her head and muttered softly: “The world in front of us feels less and less real…”

“At present, everyone’s mind is still stable. Mild hallucinations can be overcome and recognized by reason,” said a lower-ranked priest beside Polly. “The Tide just sent word. Similar hallucinations are spreading on their side as well, but the level of corruption is still low.”

“Hallucinations that are clearly bizarre aren’t that frightening. What’s frightening are the things that look perfectly normal and fit our common sense,” Polly shook her head. “Or to put it another way… what’s frightening is when we feel everything around us is normal.”

“We are already deep inside the Veil. This is close to the furthest distance anyone has ever gone,” the lower priest said carefully. “In the past, even when the Deep Sea Church used a large number of mobile lighthouses and temporary cathedrals, they only managed to push six nautical miles into the Veil…”

Polly did not reply. She only looked out through the bridge windows at the distant mist. Through the haze, she saw a ghostly green flame rising into the sky, illuminating the whole sea, its image growing slightly larger in her vision.

After a while, she broke the silence in a low voice: “We’ve slowed down…”

…

Under Duncan’s order, the Guide Vessel, blazing like a giant Sacred beacon Torch, began to slow down and edged in alongside the Vanished.

The joint fleet following this “lighthouse” reacted at once, tightening their formation as they shifted into a more compact array.

At the raised platform on the stern, Vanna stood and looked over the gathered ships.

Frankly speaking, grouping into a dense formation in a dangerous sea where enemies might be lurking was not a good idea. It would probably make many true naval experts explode in sharp, whistling curses. But in this strange, deadly border, many things simply could not be done by “common sense”.

Compared to enemy fire from afar, the risk of getting lost in the thick fog after spreading out was clearly greater. And what worried them most was not a ship that got lost in the fog—but one that got lost and then came back.

But after this whole tense and cautious journey, the joint fleet had not run into any “gunfire” at all. The only thing with them was fog. Endless fog.

“Where did those cultists go?” Vanna could not help frowning and muttering under her breath.

Footsteps sounded from behind her. Duncan’s voice followed: “How likely do you think it is that they all ran? If they really wanted to flee, they’ve had more than enough time.”

“I don’t think that group of madmen would give up their holy ground so easily—even with you here in person, there will definitely be extremists ready to die with it,” Vanna shook her head. “Their words and deeds may be blasphemous and insane, but when it comes to ‘devotion’, I still have to admit it.”

“…According to what I can feel from that Guide Vessel, we should already be near the holy ground. Its desire to ‘go home’ points to this sea,” Duncan said slowly. He walked to the rail and looked at the strangely calm “silent sea” that existed only in the border waters. “Now I’m really curious how those Annihilators discovered this place and decided there was a ‘holy

ground’ here worth settling in. I don’t see anything… Could it be that their blind faith really bought them some kind of ‘guidance’?”

As Duncan finished speaking, Vanna opened her mouth, ready to answer. But before she could say a word, a faint “thunk… thunk…” suddenly sounded from outside the hull, cutting off their conversation.

It sounded like something had drifted over and was bumping again and again against the side of the Vanished.

Duncan and Vanna shared a glance, then both strode quickly toward the source of the sound. Duncan leaned over the rail and looked down.

On the mirror-smooth sea, which had an oily sheen to it, a pitch-black shape was floating beside the hull of the Vanished. The border sea was calm and still, yet the thing on the surface bobbed up and down as if pushed by invisible waves, knocking softly against the wooden planking over and over. With each rise and fall, its outline became clearer before Duncan’s and Vanna’s eyes—

It was a pitch-black human shape.

The moment he saw it, Duncan’s gaze hardened. He lifted his hand and gestured in the air: “Get that thing on board.”

A streak of ghostly green fire flashed past. The burning Skeletal Roc dove from a nearby mast and skimmed low across the water. In almost the blink of an eye, it returned to the deck.

Soon, everyone aboard the Vanished had gathered after hearing the news.

The “human shape” Ai had hauled up lay motionless on the deck.

It was a black Humanoid Husk about one meter eighty tall. It only had the rough outline of a person. There were no facial features, no hair, not even

details on the hands and feet. It looked… exactly like a “rough husk” of clay made halfway through pinching out a doll.

Several pairs of eyes turned to Duncan at the same time. Duncan examined the black-mud rough husk with a grave expression, then slowly nodded.

“…It really is the same kind of thing as those we saw in the Deep Sea beneath Frostholm.

“It’s a ‘mortal’ in a half-finished state… from the Abyssal Deep Holy Master’s Work of Creation.”

Chapter 708: Knock Knock

The “elements” Rough Husks that had once appeared in the Deep Sea beneath Frostholm now showed up in this border sea, near the “Holy Land” of the Annihilators. This fact gave off an eerie, terrifying air, but it was not all that surprising.

After all, the “Abyssal Lord” was the thread that tied all of this together.

Morris squatted beside the humanoid Rough Husk. He took out a slender metal sampling spike and carefully pushed it toward the thing’s arm. The spike met an outer layer that was extremely tough – obviously much tougher than the skin of humans, elves, or Senkin – yet still a bit elastic, like some kind of dense, heavy-duty rubber.

He pressed harder and broke through that tough “skin”. The sampling spike turned half a circle inside the humanoid Rough Husk’s arm, and when he pulled it out, it brought with it some black, sludge-like material.

It was the familiar black sludge, but it seemed to have lost its activity. There was no sign of wriggling or reshaping at all.

“I’m starting to feel a little sick…” Shirley frowned hard. Those filthy clumps of black sludge gave her goosebumps. She could not help thinking of the chilling things that had happened back in Frostholm – the replicas that had grown in the fog, the Elder Gods’ tentacles that had kept spreading upward from the Deep Sea, the living sludge surging through pipes and sewers…

Yet Dog, who stood beside her, seemed completely unfazed. The Abyssal Hound moved closer to the humanoid Rough Husk with curiosity, circling it and sniffing all around. It looked as if Dog had found something, even pausing now and then as if lost in thought.

Shirley stared at him with open disgust: “Dog, what are you doing? You don’t think this stuff is gross at all… hey, don’t rub your head on it…”

“Dog, did you discover something?” Vanna asked seriously from the side.

“It doesn’t count as a discovery. This is my first time seeing this thing with my own eyes. Before this I only heard the captain describe it…” Dog shook his head. “I just feel like its scent… is a bit familiar.”

Duncan raised his eyebrows at that: “A bit familiar?”

“…Smells like ‘home’,” Dog muttered. “But I’m not too sure… it’s very faint. It just feels kind of familiar.”

Duncan’s expression slowly grew more solemn, but he did not speak for the moment.

Back then, in the Deep Sea under Frostholm, he had found a great number of “elements” Rough Husks. To fully burn away the hidden danger beneath Frostholm and prevent the Elder Gods’ replicant from waking, he had set fire to the Elder God tentacle that served as the “pillar”. That fire had then ignited all the Rough Husks in that section of the Deep Sea as well. Because of that, he had brought no samples back from that place. So until today, Dog had never truly come into contact with this kind of “replicant half-finished product” made by the power of the Abyssal Lord.

And now, Dog smelled the scent of the Abyssal Deep Sea, from these “half-finished products”.

Duncan faintly felt there was some kind of “problem” hidden inside Dog’s discovery.

Lucretia noticed the change on Father's face and asked, a little worried: "Do you think something is wrong?"

Duncan's expression was serious: "Why do these humanoid Rough Husks carry the scent of the Abyssal Deep Sea?"

"Is that actually wrong?" Lucretia asked, puzzled. "All these things were born from the power of the Abyssal Lord. It seems normal that they carry the scent of the Abyssal Deep Sea…"

Duncan turned his head: "From the information we have so far, 'humans' were also created by the Abyssal Lord. So why has Dog never smelled 'home' on any human body?"

The area fell silent at once. Lucretia blinked and finally realized what kind of "problem" Father had sensed.

Her gaze fell on the Rough Husk lying on the deck, that featureless lump without a face, fingers, or toes. Her expression slowly grew more serious.

Duncan spoke softly, still deep in thought: "All mortal races are derivatives of the Abyssal Deep, and the Abyssal demons are also creations of the Abyssal Lord. We treat 'humans' and 'Abyssal demons' as the two ends of a scale. So these humanoid Rough Husks… are they closer to 'human', or closer to 'Abyssal demon'?"

"…I remember you said before that these clay-doll-like Rough Husks are probably the 'half-finished products' from when the Abyssal Lord first created the mortal races. Or you could say they are rough products processed according to some original blueprint. The Elder God tentacle in the Deep Sea under Frostholm was only a partial replica of the Abyssal Lord, so it could only produce this kind of Rough Husk. But if things went a step further, these Rough Husks might become real humans…"

Lucretia slowly spoke while recalling what Father had once told her about the Frostholm incident.

“And now Dog feels that these Rough Husks carry the scent of the Abyssal Deep Sea. Or in other words, he feels that these Rough Husks… are a lot like his own kind.”

“I never said that!” Dog muttered at once, but then he dropped down, sounding much less sure. “Uh, fine… they do feel a little bit like it…”

Shirley blinked, looked at Dog, then at the captain. Her gaze swept around them all, and she still looked confused: “What are you all talking about?”

Duncan glanced at the young lady, then raised his hand and pointed at the Rough Husk on the deck: “We’re talking about the point at which ‘humans’ first split away from Abyssal demons. Or, for these Abyssal demons that already have humanoid shapes, at what point they turn into ‘humans’.”

Shirley needed a moment. Then her eyes suddenly flew wide: “What the hell?!”

Duncan did not explain further. He only nodded lightly, then turned, ready to head back to the steering platform at the stern. They were already very close to the critical line at six nautical miles. Going farther required extra caution. He planned to move the Vanished forward just a little more to confirm the situation ahead.

But just as he was about to step away, a light knocking sound came from the outer side of the hull, cutting him off and breaking everyone’s train of thought.

Right after that, more knocking sounds reached all their ears.

Something was hitting the hull. At first there were only two or three impacts. Then more – a lot more.

Vanna’s face changed slightly. She strode to the edge of the deck in just a few steps and leaned over to look down at the sea.

Black Humanoid Husks, Rough Husks shaped as if molded from mud, bobbed all around. At a glance there were at least dozens, maybe hundreds, bumping again and again against the hull of the Vanished. They rose and sank on the calm sea as if pushed by unseen waves. Knock. Knock. Knock, knock…

What lay farther out was even more chilling.

Ahead of the Vanished, out across the distant water, more blurred shapes were slowly drifting in from the misty surface. Countless humanoid Rough Husks rolled and heaved like dead logs in the water. They drifted along in the same direction, one after another slamming into the side of the Vanished. Each impact gave off a dull thud, and then they rolled away, changing their drifting path and continuing on toward the rear, toward the Radiant Star…

On the foredeck of The Rest, Polly, a goddess-officiant in the black robes of the Death Church, stood at the rail. Dark gold curls framed her tense face as she stared down at the sea. Those humanoid Rough Husks drifting in from afar like blackened driftwood filled her vision with a chill, uncanny horror.

A junior priest stood at her side, looking very uneasy: “Bishop Polly, what exactly are these things?”

“They are things born from the power of the Abyssal Lord. They probably drifted here from that so-called ‘Holy Land’,” Polly said casually. At the same time, a voice was speaking in her mind, telling her details about these humanoid Rough Husks. That voice came from the Vanished, from the “Lady Agatha” who followed Captain Duncan in the form of a shadow: “Ignore them. These things are dead. As long as we don’t touch them on purpose, they will not threaten our ironclad ships.”

“Yes, Bishop.”

The junior priest bowed his head and withdrew, but he had barely been gone for long before he hurried back to Polly again.

“Bishop! The bottom of the ship – there are some down at the bottom too!”

“The bottom of the ship?!”

Polly rushed to the lower decks. There she heard the knocking sounds echoing almost through the entire lower hold.

The impacts came in a constant stream, as if from all directions at once. Countless hard objects were drifting in the water and striking the steel hull. The sound echoed through the compartments, dull and unsettling. Polly even felt a strange illusion.

It was like countless people were outside, each holding a sledgehammer, knocking on the hull on purpose and sending a rolling echo through the ship.

Images rose in her mind without her wanting them. She pictured countless faceless humanoid Rough Husks floating in the waters around The Rest, not only on the surface but underwater as well. Hundreds and thousands of Black Mud Homunculi clung to the ship’s underside, slamming against it again and again, clawing and scraping, trying to punch through the thick steel and sink this uninvited guest that had intruded on the Holy Land…

She shook her head hard and forced those “associations”, which might cause unpredictable trouble, back down. Then she turned to the technicians who had come down with her: “Will the hull be damaged?”

“At the current level of impact, the hull won’t suffer any damage,” the artificer answered at once. “These are just collisions. The force is no more than floating driftwood in the sea… but honestly, the sound is extremely disturbing. And ever since ‘those things’ started hitting the hull near the

engine room, the steam engine has been making irregular noises while running…”

Polly’s eyes sharpened: “Have the machines been bewitched?”

“Not to a serious degree, but the machines do feel disturbed. I hope you can ask a priest from the Cathedral to come down and perform a calming mass for the boiler and the Sorting Engine.”

“Fine, I’ll notify the Cathedral and have them send someone,” Polly said at once.

Just as she finished speaking, a hoarse and blurry voice suddenly slipped into her mind. It blended with the constant knocking all around, wove through the echoes in the lower decks, as if it had condensed directly from the cold seawater outside the hull, then seeped into her heart.

“You… will become like them… just like we did…”

—

Chapter 709: Holy Land Island

On the deck of the Vanished, Vanna hurried over to Duncan: “The Tide just sent word. A large number of Humanoid Husks have drifted to their side too and are colliding with their hull. After the impacts, the Humanoid Husks linger and drift around them, as if pulled by an invisible current…”

“Not only that. Commander Orlando of The Rest also sent a message,” Agatha’s figure rose from the shadows beside Duncan. “Their ship is surrounded by floating Humanoid Husks… and something is gathering underwater, striking the bottom of the hull. The knocking is loud enough to be heard through almost the entire deck…”

She paused for a moment, as if listening to some far-off sound, then added: “Bishop Polly of The Rest says she heard whispered words near the engine room, probably coming from under the water – a voice spoke in her head: “‘You will become like them, just like we did.’”

Listening to these reports from the other main ships of the united fleet, Duncan frowned slightly. He paid special attention to the news from The Rest: “Is this mental corruption?”

“We can’t be sure yet. Bishop Polly is undergoing mental calibration in the Cathedral. For now, it looks like she really did hear some kind of ‘echo’ that haunts this sea region.”

“Any reports of ships being damaged?” Duncan thought for a moment, then asked another question.

“None so far,” Vanna said with a shake of her head. “Every impact is just those Humanoid Husks drifting with the current and knocking into the hulls. They pose no physical threat to ironclads… but some ships report that their steam engines and Sorting Engines are making strange noises, as if mildly corrupted. Overall the corruption is still light. After performing calming rituals, everything went back to normal.”

Duncan nodded with a grave expression. For a while he said nothing, only stared out at the distant sea.

Those pitch-black figures like driftwood still floated in from the thin mist at the “six-nautical-mile boundary”. They drifted in like countless drowned corpses sweeping into the fleet’s range. They looked lifeless, yet unseen forces drove them toward every ship, where they kept knocking at the hulls and hammering at the keels.

These unsettling sounds were creating mental pressure on every vessel.

But for Church elites who had gone through strict training, this level of mental strain should still be manageable. So Duncan was not too worried.

After a short moment of thought, he ordered the whole fleet to advance slowly again.

“We’re already very close to the six-nautical-mile boundary,” Lucretia could not help reminding Father from the side. “Are we really going farther in? Navigation methods don’t stay very accurate out here in the border seas. We need a safety buffer… otherwise we might accidentally cross the boundary.”

“We’re not going to cross the boundary,” Duncan said as he glanced at Lucretia. Part of his focus was still on sensing every part of the ship. “Don’t worry, Lucy. I have the most accurate enchanted sea chart in the world. It can mark the position and distance of the Vanished in the Boundless Sea in

real time. If we still can’t see the ‘Holy Land’ at six nautical miles, I’ll stop.”

Lucretia opened her mouth, seeming like she still had something to say. But when she saw Duncan’s calm and confident smile, she swallowed the words again.

Duncan shifted a part of his “gaze” into the captain’s cabin.

He could clearly “see” the enchanted sea chart on the table. It was “running” as usual, slowly changing as the Vanished sailed on.

The mist on the enchanted sea chart was slowly thinning, and the track of the Vanished’s voyage appeared clearly along the chart’s edge. The ship was moving very slowly, so on the chart the shifts in position were almost too small to notice with the naked eye. But for Duncan, who could sense the entire ship with precision, even changes too tiny for the eye on the enchanted sea chart could not escape his awareness.

Out on the sea around the Vanished, more Humanoid Husks kept drifting in from afar. Their numbers even seemed to be growing.

Suddenly, Duncan noticed something appear at the edge of the enchanted sea chart.

Through the mist, an unrecorded “marker” appeared on the parchment scroll.

The instant he sensed the change on the enchanted sea chart, he raised his head and looked toward the direction of the Vanished’s bow.

In the depths of the fog, the blurry outline of land was slowly appearing.

Right on the six-nautical-mile boundary line.

“Land!” Nina thudded up the steps onto the platform at the stern. She stared wide-eyed at the growing shadows in the mist and shouted happily: “Land

is showing up!”

Yes, land had appeared. And in this direction, there was no doubt that this land was the objective of the united fleet – the nest the Annihilators called their “Holy Land”.

The Church warships following behind the Vanished soon saw the outline of land as well. Once everyone realized that the “Holy Land” lay right at the edge of the six-nautical-mile limit, every nerve went taut.

At the stern of every Church warship, billows of white steam burst out from the tops of the shipboard Cathedrals. Consecrated oils were poured into the Holy Braziers. The seamen ran to their gun stations while quietly chanting the names of their Gods. Robed priests came out onto the decks. They poured holy water over the cannons, lit incense, and blessed the shells with prayers and divine blessings.

At the same time, more black Humanoid Husks kept drifting over from the direction of the “Holy Land”. Floating shapes still bumped into the hulls from time to time. The unsettling knocking never stopped, beating against the bottom of every ship, as if pounding on every heart.

A swirl of colorful paper scraps blew past as Lucretia appeared on the lookout platform at the top of the mast. She peered through the poor visibility toward the island appearing in the distance. After a while she returned to the deck and came back to Duncan’s side.

“I can see some lights on the island, but no signs of activity at all. The whole area feels smothered by a dead, lifeless air. Something feels wrong.”

Duncan listened to Lucretia’s report and only gave a small nod. Then he gestured to the side.

The plump White Dove swooped down from a nearby yardarm and almost slammed into his shoulder with a dull thump.

Duncan turned his head with a strange expression and looked at the dove on his shoulder: "…You should think about losing some weight."

AI tilted her head, then loudly declared her stance: "I only weigh fifty! I only weigh fifty!"

"…Forget I said anything." Duncan sighed. He ignored the noisy bird and gave her a silent order in his mind.

In the next instant, blazing flames burst from AI's body. She turned into a bony, skeletal dove and shot straight up into the sky.

Wrapped in fire, the bone dove streaked through the mist like a meteor flying in reverse, closing in on the dark island from above.

Back on the deck of the Vanished, Duncan narrowed his eyes slightly.

Through the shared vision inside the flames, an abstract, twisted, yet still recognizable bird's-eye view formed in his mind.

AI was quickly approaching the island's shore. From the view she sent back, Duncan saw the coastline, jagged and cruel as if something had torn the island out of a much larger whole. He also saw a narrow, hidden passage – a secret Harbor that would be hard to spot without viewing it from the air. Farther inland he could faintly make out roads and buildings of different heights. Many strange, sharp objects rose like stone spires across the island, spread over a large area, but their exact nature was impossible to tell.

Just as Lucretia had reported, there was no sign of activity on the island.

A vast united fleet. A blazing lighthouse of fire in the thick mist. A huge flaming monster-bird sweeping low over the Harbor. If all of that still failed to draw a reaction from the Annihilators on the island, then there was only one possibility.

“It seems there’s no one on the island – at least, no living people,” Duncan said as he kept sharing vision with AI and turned his head toward Lucretia.

Everyone on deck looked at each other.

“No living people on the island…” Vanna’s eyes widened a little. She glanced toward the land. “Did they all run? Or are they all dead? Or…”

She suddenly stopped. Her gaze swept the deck with a strange look before settling on the humanoid Rough Husk that still lay there quietly, guarded by Doll Lunie the warden.

“…Inform the people from the Deep Sea and the Death Church. We need to move closer to the island. Everyone is to stay together – no falling behind in the fog.”

Under Duncan’s order, the entire fleet began to close in on the jagged, twisted black island that gave off such an uneasy air.

The distant island grew clearer and, as the distance shrank, revealed more and more details that felt fundamentally “off”.

“Its edge looks like a fragment torn off from some much larger whole,” Duncan said, describing to the others what he saw from AI’s perspective. “We’re approaching the western coast. There are clusters of rock formations everywhere, but between the cliffs there’s a hidden waterway leading to an inner Harbor. The terrain there looks relatively flat.”

“Could a ship as big as the Vanished fit in there?” Nina asked curiously.

“It probably could, but I don’t plan to just sail straight in – and neither should the other ships,” Duncan said, thinking it through as he spoke. “We still don’t know the situation on the island. My idea is to have the fleet stop in front of that ‘gorge entrance’. Then we send a team ashore in small boats. Once we have a rough idea of the landing zone, we can send more people up.”

Everyone nodded in agreement.

Just then, Duncan seemed to sense something. He suddenly raised his head and looked forward.

He saw the large vessel ahead – the one they had seized from the cultists and used all along as the “spirit flame, the Sacred beacon Torch” – beginning to pick up speed.

It moved faster and faster, as if it had slipped its reins. Without any order from Duncan, it rushed straight toward the “Holy Land Island”.

It seemed to have lost all weight, light as a gust of wind.

In almost the blink of an eye, it swept across the misty sea and reached the cliff line at the edge of the island, where countless massive rocks jutted up like fangs.

Then it slammed into them without the slightest hesitation.

Chapter 710: “Not Right” Is Normal Here

Under everyone’s gaze, that large ship, wrapped in Ghost flames and blazing like the Sacred beacon Torch, sailed straight into the jagged cliff. Yet the explosion and thunderous impact everyone expected never came.

At the moment of impact, the ship seemed to melt. Its solid deck, hull, and keel turned into something like mud, flowed down, and slapped silently against the cliff. It looked less like a collision and more like a lump of sludge thrown against the rock face. Then the whole ship seemed to be absorbed by the island itself, fading away between those clustered, jagged stone spires.

The spirit form flames that had been burning on that ship a moment ago now burst against the island cliffs in a huge ring of fire. The green flame sea rippled along the shoreline, then spilled out after a brief delay, splashing into the water. It lit the mist-covered surface of the sea and slowly spread out in front of the joint fleet.

It all happened so suddenly that the Church fleet seemed not to have reacted yet to what had happened. But on the Vanished, Nina already stared wide-eyed and cried out: “That ship just killed itself?!”

Lucretia sounded stunned: “Dad, that ship… did it just break free of your command?”

Duncan did not answer. He only frowned, going over the vague sense that the ship had suddenly sent him just before it hit the cliff. After a long

moment, he finally broke the silence and said thoughtfully: “No… it wasn’t in a runaway state.”

“It wasn’t in a runaway state?” Lucretia looked puzzled. “Then why did it suddenly crash into the cliff…”

“The order I gave it was ‘go home’—so it obeyed,” Duncan said slowly. “I just thought a ship’s ‘home’ meant the harbor where it usually docked and was serviced. But for that ship… its ‘home’ must have been this island itself.”

Lucretia still seemed to be thinking about his words, but Vanna and Morris, who had gone through the Frostholm incident before, were already starting to understand. Morris suddenly frowned and asked: “You mean that ship was…”

“Built from the island’s ‘material’,” Duncan said, his expression serious. “At least a large part of it was.”

The loss of the Guide Vessel was an accident, but it did not have much impact on the joint fleet. They had already found the location of the Holy Land Island, and the route was now marked on the enchanted sea chart. The ghostly green spirit form flames were burning quietly on the sea, keeping the surrounding mists suppressed. A short while later, the Radiant Star found the entrance to the “fjord” that AI had seen from the air.

For the priests of the Deep Sea and the Church of Death, the investigation of “Holy Land Island” still had to go ahead as planned, despite the accident.

Two small landing boats, one launched from the Tide and the other from the Rest, soon came alongside the Vanished. Each carried eleven marines and one armed priest, all waiting for Duncan’s orders.

On the Vanished, Duncan was deciding who would go ashore with him.

“Vanna, Morris, Alice, you’re coming ashore with me.” Duncan looked over the followers on the deck and quickly picked his people. Then his gaze fell on Shirley, who was trying hard to make herself invisible. “Shirley, you’re coming too.”

“I’m not good at exploring, and I’m nowhere near as well-read as Old Gentleman…”

“I know, but we need Dog’s abilities,” Duncan cut off her muttering. “It’s a Abyssal demon, and it’s good at sensing and tracking. On this ‘Holy Land Island’ that will be very useful.”

Shirley’s expression turned a bit strange as she listened. It took her a moment to realize… her main role here was basically to be Dog’s leash…

But Duncan did not pay attention to the odd look on her face. After deciding who would go ashore, he waved to the others and said: “The rest of you stay on the ship. This place is strange. If anything feels off on board or on the sea nearby, let me know at once.”

“You don’t need me to go with you?” Lucretia stepped forward. “I’m familiar with the border, and I have a lot of experience exploring strange islands…”

“I do, just not right now,” Duncan shook his head. He clearly already had a plan. “Go back to the Radiant Star and keep an eye on that ‘Saint’. It will be very useful later. I’ll scout the island first. If I find a suitable ‘place’, I’ll send AI to pick you up.”

Lucretia thought for a moment, then nodded: “I understand.”

Duncan nodded slightly and led the people he had chosen toward the edge of the deck.

Just then, a loud clattering noise suddenly came from not far away.

Duncan looked up toward the sound and saw a small boat, fixed to the mid-deck and covered with a tarp, banging and rocking on its supports.

It was the landing skiff carried by the Vanished.

In everyone's memory, that little boat's main uses were to have two ropes tied along the side so Alice could hang up laundry, or to let Shirley sneak into it for a nap when she did not want to do homework.

Duncan silently watched the rocking boat for two or three seconds before he said: "AI will take us to the island."

The small boat went still for a moment, then began to shake even harder, thumping its bow against the wooden frame that held it in place.

Duncan: "…"

"Captain," Alice finally came over and tugged on Duncan's sleeve, whispering by his ear: "Maybe we should take it with us… I feel like it's about to cry…"

Duncan gave Alice a strange look, then glanced at the landing skiff on the deck, which really did not look very happy. He felt the whole thing was absurd, but in the end he still sighed helplessly: "Fine. We'll go ashore in the small boat too…"

As soon as he finished speaking, the little boat on the deck snapped free of the ropes and hooks holding it. The crane on the side of the deck creaked to life, lifted the skiff from its wooden supports, and lowered it into the recess along the middle deck.

The whole movement flowed smoothly, as if it was afraid the captain might change his mind.

Duncan: "…"

In any case, with the landing skiff launched from the Vanished, there were now three small boats leaving the joint fleet. They followed the giant rocky cliffs along the edge of “Holy Land Island”, found the hidden entrance that led toward the island’s interior, and began to move inside.

After they passed through the “fjord gate” that looked like the open jaws of some huge beast, they saw tall, twisted clusters of stone pillars on both sides, a wide, calm dark-blue waterway, and mist still hanging in every direction.

The three small boats moved forward carefully through the fog. In the hazy mist, they could just make out vague shapes of harbor facilities on the shore ahead. A few lights, almost like illusions, glowed quietly in the fog, like cold, murky eyes floating in the air.

The boat carrying Duncan and the others did not need a helmsman and could sail on its own, while the landing boats from the Tide and the Rest were driven by small steam cores. The sound of the steam cores at work broke the stillness of the fjord. The splashing of the three boats cutting through the water echoed off the cliffs on both sides and blended into a single, blurry noise.

Vanna suddenly frowned.

She turned to look at the captain, only to see that he was also frowning, staring toward some point in the fog. Behind and to the side of the landing skiff, the two steam launches from the Tide and the Rest seemed to have sensed something as well and were starting to slow down.

The mingled echoes in the fjord slowly grew weaker.

Vanna tilted her head, listening carefully, and asked quietly: “Do you hear it?”

Shirley had not noticed any anomaly, but she could feel the change in the air around them. She twisted her head nervously and asked: “H-hear what?”

The faint scrape of chain came from the shadows as Dog slowly raised its head: “There’s the sound of a fourth boat… in the fog, moving forward with us.”

Shirley’s face changed a little. She lowered her voice: “What the heck?”

Duncan said nothing. He only lifted his hand, signaling them to keep going.

The sound of the propellers driven by machines rose again, and the blurred noise returned to the fjord. In that humming, rumbling, and splashing, even Shirley heard the “fourth boat”.

This time the sound was even clearer than before. Shirley could even pick out a rumble in it that was like a steam engine, only deeper, along with the splash of a bow cutting through the waves.

She stared wide-eyed, trying to find where the sound was coming from, but all the noise blended with the echoes in the fjord. It rumbled all around them, impossible to place.

She could only be sure that there really was a fourth boat, hidden in the fog around them, very close. At times… it even felt as if it was right beside them.

It seemed that Morris had suddenly picked something out. He stared hard at the misty water, then took a strange device from inside his coat, something shaped like a lens, and looked in that direction through it.

A hazy shadow appeared in the lens, like an abstract, unreal boat.

But in the next second, the phantom in the fog was washed over by a layer of eerie green. Imaginary spirit form flames swallowed it in an instant and then vanished just as fast.

The sound of the fourth boat disappeared.

Alice stared in confusion at the brief flash of fire in the fog, then looked up at Duncan: “Captain, what was that?”

“I don’t know,” Duncan shook his head. “Maybe something in the fog was trying to ‘imitate’ us, or maybe it was just an illusion born from the special environment here… Either way, it’s not a big problem. Being ‘not right’ is just part of daily life on the border.”

Alice gave a little “oh” as if she half understood, then turned her head to look at the water in front of the boat.

“Ah, we’re here.”

As the doll spoke, the harbor that had been hazy in the mist suddenly came into clear view.

The three boats came to the dock.

Chapter 711: Vanna’s “Reputation”

In the drifting mist, the three small boats slipped in without a sound and stopped at the end of a gentle ramp in a corner of the harbor.

Duncan was the first to step onto the eerie little island that the Annihilators called the “Holy Land”.

All around was silent. The drifting mist carried a chill. Inside the harbor, man-made structures stood at different heights, blurred by the fog. The outlines of the buildings seemed to merge with the terrain in the distance. A few dim yellow lights shone through the far-off mist, but they did nothing to make anyone feel at ease.

“There’s no sound at all…” Shirley felt the cold hanging in the mist. She hugged her arms and rubbed them as she looked around and muttered: “Dog, can you smell any ‘people’?”

“No smell of the living. Just a faint scent of the dead, mixed into a heavy Abyssal Deep aura,” Dog muttered. It carefully felt out the area around them, blood-red light flickering in its empty eye sockets. “…It feels more and more like ‘home’. Not only the aura, even the ‘atmosphere’… is a bit similar.”

It lifted its head and stared with its hollow eyes toward the island’s interior, hidden in the fog, sounding a bit confused: “A lot of things here feel like my ‘home’, but… not quite. I can’t put the feeling into words.”

“So this is what your home is like, Dog?” Shirley’s focus was clearly elsewhere. “No wonder you said the Abyssal demons back home spend

their time biting each other or gnawing on rocks. Your living conditions are awful…”

“I don’t like the feel of this place,” Vanna said, frowning hard as she kept watch on the surroundings. “It keeps reminding me of Frostholm back then…”

Shirley waved a hand: “Fog, silent streets, writhing mud, and elements replicants suddenly popping out, right? We all get it…”

Duncan paid no mind to the chatter around him. After he confirmed there was not a single living person nearby, he waved to the marines who were disembarking from the two other boats, signaling everyone to follow. Then he started toward the dim yellow lights glowing in the fog.

The air around them felt eerie and unsettling, keeping everyone on high alert. Before this, they had all imagined what kinds of dangers might hide in the nest that Annihilators called the “Holy Land”. They had imagined thousands of armed, fanatical cultists, countless traps and flesh-and-blood monsters built by demon worshippers, even a powerful fleet secretly forged by the Cult of Annihilation that would ambush the expedition in this mist…

But a “ghost island” with no trace of living people had not been in any of those plans.

Vanna reached back and took down her alloy greatsword, gripping it tightly. This time they had plenty of time to prepare for the expedition, so she did not have to make do with a greatsword of frozen ice like she had in those rushed fights before.

Having her familiar “battle partner” in hand made her feel a little more at ease.

Footsteps approached. A young lady in fitted armor similar in style to Vanna’s, with a greatsword strapped to her back, walked over.

Vanna remembered that she was the leading priest sent down from the Tide, the one in charge of those eleven marines.

Under Vanna's curious and slightly puzzled gaze, the young priest of the Goddess with the greatsword on her back came up beside her and said quietly, a little excited: "You're Lady Vanna Wayne, right? The legendary Inquisitor from Pland, the strongest in history…"

"…Legendary Inquisitor? I didn't know I'd picked up that title," Vanna frowned, looking a bit embarrassed. "But yes, I am Vanna Wayne. What do you need from me?"

"I…I'm Amber," the priest of the Goddess said quickly. "I've heard many of your deeds… like how you leaped off a cliff to slay the Eldritch God spawn that invaded the city-state. How you jumped from the roof of the Cathedral to cut down the cultist trying to destroy it. And how you jumped from the sea-cliff lighthouse…"

Before Amber could finish, Vanna already felt she could not take it anymore. She waved her hand quickly: "Stop. I don't have that many 'leap down and slay' records. Legends always exaggerate."

"You're… you're very humble," Amber said with a smile. She then pointed at the greatsword on her back. It was already much larger than the standard steel swords most Deep Sea priests used, yet it was still far smaller than the alloy greatsword in Vanna's hand. "I'm trying to learn your fighting style too. My mentor says it's the oldest, yet most practical, killing technique in Storm Swordsmanship… Of course, I'm still far from your level…"

Vanna opened her mouth and managed to squeeze out: "Ah, well… keep it up."

"I'm still working hard," Amber nodded vigorously. Then she hesitated and asked: "But… how can I get power like yours? I've heard so many of your

battle stories… Do you have some special training method?”

Vanna’s expression grew even more awkward. She glanced toward Duncan without thinking, but saw that the captain had no intention of stepping in. After holding it in for a few seconds, she finally blurted out: “Eat more meat.”

Amber: “…Huh?”

“And drink more hot water, go to bed early, get up early, keep a regular schedule,” Vanna added, as if even she felt her answer was not very convincing.

Amber’s expression slowly shifted into something one “huh?” could no longer cover—it was more like blank shock: “Th-that’s… all it takes?”

“Yes. And remember to pray every day. Tell the Goddess your doubts and confusion. Don’t carry that pressure and hesitation over to the next day,” Vanna nodded. “And last, the most important thing—”

Amber’s expression changed at last. She became very serious at once: “The most important thing?”

Vanna thought for a moment, then looked at the junior in front of her with a very serious face and said earnestly: “Don’t make random vows when you have nothing better to do. And if you’ve already sworn one, don’t add more to it just because you’re fired up. You’ll trap yourself.”

Amber’s face went blank again: “…Huh?”

But Vanna had already walked away. Leaving the junior who embarrassed her behind, she took a few quick steps to catch up to Duncan, head down.

But Duncan had been listening to the talk behind him the whole time. When he saw Vanna walk up, he finally smiled and said: “Sounds like you’re very

popular among your own people—even though you've officially stepped down as an Inquisitor and left the public eye."

"…I run into this sometimes. It happened even more back in the city-state," Vanna said with her head down. In front of the captain, she could finally complain a little about these "little troubles not worth mentioning to outsiders". "And no matter how many times it happens, I never get used to it."

Morris took a pipe from his pocket and held it between his teeth without lighting it. After hearing this, he muttered: "And I don't know why, but the ones chasing after her are always young ladies…"

Duncan immediately gave the Inquisitor beside him a very odd look, only to see her wearing a deadpan, hopeless expression: "…Please don't look at me like that… I don't know why either…"

What could Duncan say to that? Right now he only felt that it was a miracle this beautiful maiden warrior could still have a normal friend like Heidi… Maybe it had something to do with Heidi being a science student?

In any case, it had little to do with him. It was just interesting to see that the usually calm and reliable Vanna also had such a flustered, awkward side.

Just then, on the other side of the group, Shirley suddenly seemed to trip on something and stumbled forward: "Whoa, what the—"

Dog reacted at once, jerking its neck back and yanking on the chain to stop Shirley from pitching forward: "What happened?!"

Shirley steadied herself and turned back, grumbling: "What kind of lousy road is this? Something just tripped me up and I—"

She stopped mid-sentence. Her eyes widened at the spot where she had almost tripped, and the rest of her words turned into a short yelp: "What?!"

Several gazes instantly followed her line of sight.

Duncan also saw what had almost tripped Shirley—it was an arm.

Strictly speaking, it was an arm “set” into the road, fused with the surface around it, a pitch-black “arm” that looked as if it was made from hardened sludge!

Duncan’s eyes narrowed at once. He strode quickly to the black arm.

It was a bent upper arm, elbow, and forearm. Its black, muddy texture blended completely with the road around it, as if it had grown straight up out of the ground.

It was hard not to imagine that beneath the surface of the road, hidden from sight, there might be a whole body connected to that arm.

Almost at the same moment, Amber, the Deep Sea priest of the Goddess walking not far away, spotted something in the fog and called out: “There’s one here too!”

Amber had found a section of torso sticking up from the road, attached to a damaged head and an arm that seemed to be straining forward. The arm and head looked just like the humanoid rough husks the joint fleet had seen floating on the sea near Holy Land Island—black as sludge and lacking clear details in their limbs and facial features.

But its pose was enough to make one picture the horrors of that “humanoid rough husk” struggling to drag itself out of some devouring substance.

Duncan stared grimly at the body “set” into the road. A scene rose in his mind. The ground had softened like mud. The owner of this body had been swallowed by the road beneath his feet. His body had melted like slurry into another mass of mud. His desperate struggle had only delayed death for a moment. Then, after that short and useless effort, he had been left here forever…

But what Shirley and Amber had found was only the beginning.

Within half a minute, as the marines widened their search, they found more human bodies… all fused into the surroundings.

They were everywhere in the fog, dense and countless.

Chapter 712: Peeking at the Truth

They were everywhere.

After the landing party left the shallow shore and walked some distance toward the interior of the Holy Isle, that hair-raising scene finally appeared before everyone’s eyes.

Humanoid Husks that looked as if they were made of pitch-black sludge could be seen everywhere. It was as if the environment around them had swallowed them and “embedded” them into all kinds of places—the ground, the walls, the boulders along the road, even the tree trunks. They had completely merged with whatever had devoured them, and now stood frozen on this Holy Isle that no longer held any living people, like countless strange and frightening sculptures. Every “sculpture” showed a posture of struggle that told everyone one simple fact—

They had once been alive.

Shirley felt her scalp crawl. Those black human shapes that could appear at any time out of the fog, half fused into walls or the ground, made goosebumps run all over her body. She hugged her arms and followed carefully at Duncan’s side, trying her best to avoid the limbs or heads that strained upward from the road as she muttered: “Those cultists… are they all dead? All dead here? Then those things we saw on the sea when we came over—were those them too? Don’t tell me the whole Cult of Annihilation ended up like this?”

“The Annihilators in other parts of the world are still active. They’ve infiltrated countless city-states. They won’t be wiped out that easily,” Vanna said, frowning as she watched their surroundings. “But at the very least, there should be no Annihilators still alive in this ‘sanctuary’… This fanatical dark Cult has finally taken a serious blow. That is at least some good news.”

“Good news, but not very relaxing,” Morris said carefully. “The key problem now isn’t how many Annihilators died here, but how they died, and how they ended up like this…”

Morris paused and looked up, letting his gaze sweep across the blurry buildings in the fog. “This is the ‘sanctuary’ they have run for who knows how many years. They treated this place as a safe harbor to hide from the Church’s pursuit. They even built a town and the Harbor here. That means this little border island was always a safe and stable place… at least, it was until the island started to devour them.”

“Devour…” Shirley repeated the word the Old Scholar had used, then suddenly tensed. She stared at the ground beneath her feet. “This place isn’t going to ‘eat’ us too, right?! What if the ground suddenly sinks and we turn into things like those…”

She was clearly not the only one worried about that. Tension was also building among the assault squad members. Even though everyone here was an elite of the Church, and “professionals” trained to handle all kinds of anomalies along the border seas, it was still hard not to feel nervous in the face of the strange situation on the Holy Isle.

But just as Duncan was about to say something, Alice, walking beside him, spoke first: “It won’t.”

Shirley did not realize at first that the doll was answering her question. “Huh?”

“It won’t devour us,” Alice said casually, as if it were nothing. “Because the Restoration Protocol has already ended. This place has settled down again.”

The group suddenly stopped.

Duncan realized something. He stared into Alice’s eyes and asked: “Did you ‘see’ something again?”

Alice stopped a beat after everyone else. When she heard the captain’s words, she showed a blank, confused expression. “Huh?”

Shirley spoke up right away: “The Restoration Protocol has ended. You just said that.”

“…What Restoration Protocol? I didn’t say anything just now…” Alice scratched her hair. Her confusion did not look fake at all (and of course, she could not pull off that level of acting anyway). “Why are you all looking at me?”

Duncan stared at Alice for a while longer. He knew this doll never lied to him, so at last he only nodded slowly and quickly exchanged a look with Morris and Vanna.

“There are no extra mental signatures nearby,” Morris said.

“We keep going,” Duncan said with a nod. He led the group deeper into the island. At the same time, he silently moved a little closer to Alice, ready to watch the doll at any moment.

The landing party soon walked along the main street of the small Harbor. After they passed through a patch of thick white fog, they came out into an open square.

Vanna frowned as she looked around. “It’s hard to imagine that those cultists could build a place like this. I wonder how long it took them to make all of this.”

All across the square they could still see black humanoid Rough Husks “embedded” into the ground and fused with the things around them.

Judging from the poses of those half-exposed bodies and where they lay, it seemed that when some event occurred, these people still had a last few minutes—or a dozen minutes—to run for their lives. They had sprinted from the island’s interior toward the open sea. Every “body” on the square faced the coast. Some of them even seemed to have tried using spells to save themselves. The ground around some Rough Husks showed scars of acid and explosions. It looked as if they had still been alive in the first moments of being devoured, and had tried to gouge themselves free with brutal, desperate means—but it had done nothing at all.

They had all become these chilling black “sculptures” on the square. This process of “transformation” might have been the direct cause of their deaths.

Duncan walked slowly between the eerie black “sculptures”.

All of a sudden, he stopped. His gaze fell on one of the Rough Husks.

Vanna noticed at once. “Captain?”

“This one moved just now.” Duncan walked up to the Rough Husk whose upper body alone stuck up above the ground. He stared at it and spoke in a low voice.

Right under his eyes, the pitch-black figure shifted a little again. Its head slowly, stiffly lifted, and its arm stretched forward little by little.

It moved very, very slowly. If one was not staring straight at it, it was almost impossible to see it move at all.

It was still slowly “running away” toward the coast.

Shirley felt all the hair on her body stand up.

She suddenly had the feeling that the other Rough Husks around them were moving too. She felt they were all still alive, all slowly struggling and crawling toward the shore. She felt that their featureless round heads were all turning toward her, and that countless invisible gazes were landing on her at once.

Her heart pounded wildly. The tension that had been building in her ever since they landed felt like it was soaking into every blood vessel. She felt a sharp, stabbing pain in the arm that connected her to Dog. It reminded her of when she had just formed the symbiotic pact with Dog and her body was still not used to it. She had not felt this pain in many years.

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw chains.

Countless chains stretched out from the Rough Husks that the ground had swallowed. They grew slowly in the empty air, as if they wanted to wrap around her, or around Dog. Shirley could barely tell the difference between herself and Dog anymore. She felt her thoughts tangling together with Dog's. She felt as if she had also become an "individual" similar to Dog, and Dog… Dog's humanity and wisdom were slowly shedding away into something else…

"…We dug too deep…"

A voice that sounded like countless throats speaking on top of one another drilled into Shirley's head. It rumbled as if trying to bore a hole in her memories.

Countless phantom chains spread in from every side of the Holy Isle and quietly latched onto her and Dog.

"…We dug down to the source…"

Shirley slowly lifted her head. Dazed yet driven by instinct, she looked toward a certain direction in the interior of the Holy Isle, as if something

over there strongly drew her gaze.

“…We are the same as them… The source revealed a truth to us…”

Countless stormlike fragments poured into Shirley’s mind. Within the flashing, chaotic shards of light and shadow, strange “impressions” swept across her memory—the extinguished Sun, murky daylight, the howling and booming in the fog, ecstatic believers, guidance, revelation, digging, a holy cavern, a secret chamber, blinding lights, alarms, writhing Shadows, and then… the Holy Isle suddenly coming to life.

This island was alive.

They had dug up something they never should have touched—at the moment when the Sun went out.

Those layered voices still roared in Shirley’s mind. A “truth”—a truth that had instantly corrupted all the Annihilators on the Holy Isle and transformed them into Rough Husks—was being poured into her consciousness bit by bit—

“…Humans are a kind of Abyssal Demon that has been highly differentiated. Abyssal Demons are the original molds that were contained in the Abyssal Deep Sea, because humanity and wisdom could not be poured into them…”

Shirley’s eyes slowly widened.

Through the shared sight between her and Dog, she saw this world clearly for the first time.

But she only saw it for an instant.

In the moment when her humanity and reason were about to fall apart, she felt a warm flame light up inside her soul. The dark wriggling things in front of her and the flood of incomprehensible information suddenly shrank

and collapsed into nothing but a small island in the fog. Then she felt a rough, big hand gently press down on her hair.

She and Dog jerked awake at the same time. Instinctively, they both backed away, wanting to get far from the countless Rough Husks here.

She tripped on a chain under her foot and fell backward in a mess.

But the captain caught her thin arm.

“Looks like you saw something,” Duncan said. He felt the feedback from the flame mark and only spoke gently after he was sure Shirley’s sanity was slowly stabilizing. “What did you see?”

“This island is alive!” Shirley finally came fully to her senses. Her eyes flew wide. “We’re standing on a piece of the Abyssal Lord’s flesh!”

Chapter 713: Shirley Still in Shock

“This island… the whole island was a part of an Elder God. Everything on the island… the stones, the soil, those things that only look like trees, all of it was the same thing…

“The Annihilators who lived on this island used its stuff to build houses and make ships. They ate the things that grew out of this soil. Day after day they held rituals and summoned Demons… tying themselves to the whole island…

“There really aren’t any living people left on the island. Everyone got eaten by ‘it’, by this island… Those idiots… those stupid cultists touched something deep inside the island and woke it up…”

Shirley sat on the ground at the edge of the square with her knees in her arms, speaking in broken bits about the things she had just seen. The fright had not left her. Fear still weighed deep in her mind. The shock of briefly peeking at the “Truth” had put heavy pressure on her sanity. Even though the captain had pulled her out at the last moment, her head still buzzed, and many fuzzy “memories” still poked around in her thoughts.

Dog sat by Shirley’s side. With its grim, terrifying skeletal body, it gently rubbed against her thigh, trying to comfort her shaken heart in its own way. It helped at least a little. Shirley was slowly recovering.

Duncan sat beside Shirley as well. He shielded her mind so those corruption-laden pieces of knowledge would not affect her, and at the same

time he asked with interest: “They touched something deep inside the island? What exactly did they do?”

Shirley hesitated and searched through her messy memories. Too much information had flooded into her head all at once just now. It came from the “memories” left inside this living island. She had had no time to sort it, think about it, or even understand it. Now those chaotic memories slowly rolled up again from the depths of her mind, and some useful fragments finally became clear.

“They… they dug too deep.”

“Dug too deep?” Morris frowned at once. “What were they digging?”

“At the center of the island, there was a passage leading underground…” Shirley frowned tightly as she finally pulled out some more useful fragments. “It was when the Sun went out…!”

“When the Sun went out?” Morris’s eyes changed at once. He repeated the words and, almost without thinking, exchanged a look with Vanna and the captain.

Shirley suddenly seemed more alert. She matched the voice she had “heard” with the messy images she had seen, then spoke quickly: “Yeah, that time! After the Sun went out, there was still daylight over the Holy Isle. The cultists on the island all stayed ‘awake’… Then it was like they got some kind of revelation, and they started digging in the center of the island. There was already a cavern there, with black rock deep inside. They went crazy digging downward and found a secret chamber, but the chamber was sealed…”

Shirley paused. Her tone became less sure. “They wanted to get into the chamber, but it seems they never had time to break it, or even touch that big door, before something happened…”

Amber walked over from the side. This young priestess of the Deep Sea Goddess was extremely interested in what Shirley was saying. “So the cultists on the island were all killed because they triggered the defense mechanism of this ‘living island’?”

Shirley blinked. She was about to nod, but then felt she had forgotten something very important. She hesitated, then shook her head.

“…No. They weren’t killed by a ‘defense mechanism’…” She slowly recalled and bit by bit understood the “information” that still circled in her mind. After a few minutes of sorting and thinking, she finally understood that “truth”. “They were killed by a… ‘piece of knowledge’…”

Her words had barely fallen when Morris reacted at once beside her: “Don’t say it.”

Almost at the same time, Amber had already pulled out the storm Goddess’s charm amulet from her clothes and used its sharp end to pierce her own palm. The silent death priest who led the group took out the consecrated ash casket of divine blessing. The more than twenty assault squad members all hurried to shield themselves with charm amulets and sacred relics.

Morris cast several layers of mental wards on himself in an instant. He then wrapped Rahm’s charm amulet and a colorful rune bead bracelet around his wrist. Only then did he let out a breath and nod to Shirley. “You can talk now.”

Shirley was startled by the scene around her. She asked without thinking: “…Is all that really necessary?”

“Yes,” Vanna said seriously as she looked at Shirley. “Because this is a ‘piece of knowledge’ that instantly killed all the Annihilators on the entire island. From what you described, it is tied to the rituals they carried out for years, but this knowledge could still be dangerous.”

Morris added from the side: “Normally, if an investigator happens to gain hidden knowledge and survives it, the safest and most professional thing to do is to copy the content onto parchment sheets using ‘Sacred Cipher’ that has received the Four Gods’ divine blessing. That way you can weaken and filter out the corruption carried by the information. Do you know Sacred Cipher?”

Shirley thought for a moment, then shook her head honestly. “…No. I don’t.”

Morris spread his hands. “That’s fine. You can tell us now.”

Shirley scratched her cheek. That little break had actually relaxed her tense nerves a bit. After she took a moment to put her thoughts in order, she repeated the words she had “heard” just now—

“Humans are a kind of Abyssal Demon that has been highly differentiated. Abyssal Demons are the original molds that were contained in the Abyssal Deep Sea, because humanity and wisdom could not be poured into them.”

The square stayed quiet for a few seconds.

Alice was the first to break the silence. She blinked and looked at Shirley. “…That’s it?”

“That’s it,” Shirley said with a nod. “Just that one sentence… but after those cultists learned this ‘truth’, they almost instantly turned into these… disgusting, terrifying things.”

Shirley half understood what she was saying, and Alice half understood what she was hearing. But beside them, a thoughtful and knowing look slowly appeared on Duncan’s face.

He slowly stood up, muttering as he thought: “That’s not just one sentence… That sentence explains a lot.”

Amber lowered her head and traced Gamona's Holy Emblem on her chest with her fingers. "Goddess have mercy…"

Morris's mouth twitched. "…Humans are a type of Abyssal Demon. Even in the Cult of Annihilation's theories, that sounds a bit too extreme."

"This isn't the first time we've run into this kind of 'extreme' information," Vanna said, shaking her head with a strange look. "Not since we first got The Blasphemous Tome." She lifted her head and looked around at the assault squad members sent down from the Tide and the Rest.

There was surprise, deep thought, and confusion on their faces—but no one seemed shaken.

This was a unit that specialized in handling border affairs. Strong will and stable minds were basic traits. Given how things really were out on the border seas, "keeping your cool in the face of unbelievable information and knowledge" was probably already carved into their bones.

"No wonder those 'Humanoid Husks' floating on the sea reeked of Abyssal Demons…" Amber said suddenly, lost in thought. "I've heard the rumor that the Abyssal Lord created all living things during the Third Long Night, but I never thought of understanding the tie between humans and Abyssal Demons from this angle… If this is true, it really could explain the Annihilators' summoning ability, and how their symbiotic pacts with Abyssal Demons work…"

As she spoke, her gaze could not help drifting to Dog, who was still lying by Shirley's legs.

Dog noticed Amber's look at once and raised its head. "Don't look at me. My situation with Shirley isn't the same as those cultists—and I'm not like my brainless relatives either. I'll have you know I've at least completed the

great circle of a high school education. I might even be half a step into a City-State University…”

Shirley was left staring by Dog’s last two lines. “…Dog, what are you talking about?”

Dog muttered under its breath: “I don’t know either. The captain taught me…”

Amber opened her mouth, wearing a complicated expression. “Even though I heard about it before, I still wouldn’t have believed there were Abyssal Demons with ‘hearts’ in this world if I hadn’t seen it with my own eyes… Sorry. I didn’t mean anything by that.”

Dog grumbled: “You’d better not. I’m with the captain…”

Duncan did not pay attention to Dog’s muttering. After confirming that Shirley was stable, he broke the silence. “We can talk about the link between humans and Demons later. For now, we need to think about our next move.”

As he spoke, he turned his head and looked toward the direction in the island’s interior that Shirley had pointed to earlier.

“Shirley, do you still remember the exact place where they were digging?”

“Yeah,” Shirley nodded at once, again and again. “I remember that part pretty clearly. I even know the way.”

“Then our next target is the ‘secret chamber’ those cultists dug out,” Duncan said. His gaze soon shifted to Amber and the other assault squad members. “But there’s a problem—are you going to come with us any farther? The area ahead may not be as gentle as the Harbor district.”

“…Captain, we’re not canaries that need protecting,” Amber said, her expression turning serious. “We’ve always dealt with the ‘strange things’

along the border, including many dangerous and bizarre existences like this island. We have our own experience and methods."

Duncan looked at her serious face and stayed silent for a few seconds. At last he slowly nodded.

"All right. Then we keep going deeper."

Chapter 714:

As they went deeper into the interior of Sanctum Isle, the surroundings grew quieter and quieter. The wind no longer sounded. No birds chirped, and no streams murmured. A strange silence gathered in the mist and hung over the team.

Yet this extreme quiet only made everyone more uneasy. When all the sounds that should have belonged to nature faded away, the idea that “this island is alive” began to take over, out of control. Shirley kept feeling as if eyes were resting on her from within the fog. It felt as if the island itself was watching and judging the uninvited guests who had broken into this place. Even the mist that slowly drifted around the group seemed to take on the taste of a “watcher”.

The team still moved forward, heading toward the “dig site” that had appeared in Shirley’s mind.

After they left the Harbor district, a not-so-wide path led toward the center of the isle. It seemed to be a road the cultists had opened up long ago. It lay between two pitch-black rock walls. There were no signs along the way. At the base of the rock walls on both sides of the path, they sometimes saw black stones that looked like clusters of crystals.

Duncan’s gaze was drawn to those black “stone clusters”. These clusters were not rare on the island. On the cliffs on the west side of the isle, stones like these, even larger in scale, “grew” almost everywhere. They looked like some strange “plant” that had pushed its way out of the ground and rock face. It made people very curious how they had formed.

Even with Morris's learning, he could not explain these stone clusters from a simple geological angle. But since the whole island was, as Shirley said, "alive", it did not seem strange for such odd things to appear here.

Maybe these twisted stones really had "grown" from the island, like some kind of secretion from Elder Gods.

Under Amber's command, several marines in the squad carefully collected samples from those clusters. They also scraped a lot of dark, powdery material from the nearby rock walls. They stored these Sanctum Isle samples with great care in metal tubes that had received a divine blessing, and several specific people in the team each carried some.

All along the way, they kept doing the same sort of thing. They worked together smoothly and seemed very practiced. It almost did not slow the team's progress at all. It was clear this was not their first time doing it.

"Any Boundary Samples might come in handy. Some of them have incredible practical properties. Some can help us uncover the secrets of the world and deepen our understanding of supernatural power," Amber explained to Duncan. "Many people think the Boundary is a place where there is nothing, that it holds nothing but fog and seawater. But actually… shapes from the Mortal Realm often appear in the mist, and every year we have to handle almost double-digit 'entity incidents'…"

She paused for a moment, then added: "Lady Lucretia should know this very well. She often works with the Church in the field of boundary exploration…"

"I've heard her mention it," Duncan nodded calmly. "She said this is the main source of income for the Radiant Star when it operates in the Boundary. Truth Academy is the most generous buyer when it comes to Boundary Samples. Flamebearer is always the slowest payer. The Deep Sea Church has a good reputation in these deals, but its 'receiving' standards are

very strict. Sometimes their whole review and registration process ends up even slower than Flamebearer."

Amber looked a little embarrassed: "…Not every Church is as rich as Truth Academy. They can buy a dozen city-states just on the licensing of their steam-core reactor boiler technology, while we still have to think about our yearly budget."

Duncan said: "…That is a very Mortal Realm kind of reason."

"Do you feel… like it's colder than before?" Shirley suddenly broke the silence. She hugged her arms, rubbing them as she muttered: "I keep feeling wind blowing over. My arms are almost frozen stiff…"

"Cold?" Vanna frowned at that. "I don't really feel it… but the fog is thicker than before. The road ahead is getting harder to see… hmm?"

Vanna suddenly stopped. Her gaze locked onto Shirley's arm: "Shirley, the chain on your arm…"

Shirley froze for a second. She lifted her arm, confused: "Huh? What about the chain?"

The rattling of iron links echoed in the mist. The pitch-black Barbed Chain connected her arm to Dog's cervical spine, just like always.

Vanna's brows knitted tight. She stared hard at the black chain on Shirley's arm, then shook her head a little, unsure: "…It's back to normal again… but just now, for a moment, I thought I saw the chain on your arm broken."

"What?!" Shirley's eyes went wide at once. Even her voice sounded flustered. "Hey… don't scare me! Did you really see that?!"

As she spoke, she quickly lifted her arm and yanked the chain, dragging Dog right in front of her. She held his huge skull close: "Dog, did you feel anything?"

“No…” Dog was rattled too by Vanna’s words. “She must have seen it wrong…”

But Vanna still kept her brows furrowed. She knew very well that what she had caught in that brief daze was hard to believe, but her Inquisitor training pushed her into full alert almost at once: “Shirley, Dog, you really didn’t feel anything strange?”

Shirley and Dog answered in unison: “Nothing at all.”

“Let me take a look.” Duncan strode over, grabbed the black chain between Shirley and Dog, and lifted it up to examine it closely.

Shirley watched nervously from the side. Only after a long time did she finally gather the courage to ask: “Is… is there anything wrong with it?”

A wisp of ghostly green flame flowed over Duncan’s fingertips. It seeped between the links like water. After a while, he shook his head lightly: “I can’t see anything.”

“What would happen if the chain broke?” Even Alice finally realized how serious this was and asked in a tense voice.

“I don’t know… If the chains binding those Annihilators and contracted demons broke, they usually just died on the spot. Neither the people nor the demons could survive. But my situation with Dog is different…” Shirley spoke in a rush, clearly frightened. “Besides, under normal circumstances this chain can’t break. It’s really tough… how could it possibly break…”

Duncan suddenly reached out and patted Shirley on the shoulder.

Shirley flinched and looked up at him, uneasy.

“Go back to the ship,” Duncan said to her.

Seeing her confusion, Duncan went on: “Something feels off. To be cautious, I think you should return to the Vanished. You shouldn’t keep

going deeper into this island.”

Shirley finally understood. She hesitated a little, then nodded. But right then, Dog suddenly stepped forward. For once, he did not obey the captain’s order: “No, Captain. I think… Shirley and I should stay with you on the island.”

Duncan frowned slightly: “Why?”

Dog hesitated for a moment, then spoke as if he had made up his mind: “First, going back to the Vanished right now might not be safer than staying by your side.”

Duncan did not speak, only signaled for Dog to go on with his eyes.

“Second… I’m afraid that even if we leave Sanctum Isle now, it might not help,” Dog said after choosing his words. “I don’t think Miss Vanna ‘saw it wrong’. And in an environment like this, even if she really did see something wrong, we still have to treat it as real… Something might truly be wrong. Just now in the plaza, Shirley was clearly affected by Sanctum Isle. She saw many things she should not have seen…

“In my experience, simply leaving the scene after something like that does not solve the problem. Instead, after a period of time, it often breaks out into a bigger, uncontrollable mess. corruption follows you like a shadow and grows when you run from it, and the way to truly solve it usually lies only at the source.”

Shirley understood what Dog meant. She nervously glanced at the foggy road ahead: “You mean… we still have to keep going in?”

“We must go forward. If we don’t figure out what is happening on this island, and we don’t figure out what is wrong with the chain between you and me, I won’t be at ease,” Dog said in a low voice. “And… like I just said, going back to the Vanished now might not be safe either.”

Shirley opened her mouth, as if she still wanted to say something. But then she suddenly heard Dog's voice pass through the symbiotic pact chain and sound directly in her mind—

"Shirley, stay by the captain's side. Trust my judgment. It's safer with him, even if it means going with him into Subspace."

Shirley turned her head and saw Dog quietly watching her. In his hollow skull eye sockets, the blood-red glow flickered.

Dog seemed to have sensed something coming.

As a demon from the Abyssal Deep, Dog sometimes had vague, hard-to-explain premonitions.

Dog usually could not explain clearly to others what those premonitions meant, but Shirley had always believed his judgment without question.

So she slowly nodded: "Alright, then let's keep going deeper."

"Are you sure?" Duncan looked at Shirley very seriously. "If we go deeper, there may be more things we can't predict."

[Yes. The danger in the environment was relative. The safety by the captain's side was absolute.]

For some reason, that sentence suddenly flashed through Shirley's mind. It was not Dog's voice through their mental link. It felt more like a judgment that had appeared from her own thoughts.

She blinked, then nodded again: "I'm sure. I feel like I'm still in good shape."

"…Alright." Once Duncan confirmed how firm she was, he withdrew his gaze. Then he stretched out his hand and pressed it on the head of the girl who was too thin and short from childhood malnutrition. He spoke very seriously: "Stay near me. Don't fall behind."

“Okay!”

Chapter 715:

After going down a long slope and passing through a small town where no living people remained, only many humanoid Rough Husks embedded in the ground and rock walls, the exploration team entered a valley filled with strange black stones.

The entrance to this valley was hidden, buried in a mass of tangled remnants that looked like thorny plants. But the “memory” in Shirley’s mind clearly pointed out the exact spot.

The black rocks in the valley were jagged and twisted, forming unsettling, complex shapes. They did not look like the result of natural weathering, but they were clearly not carved by human hands either.

They were more like deformed freaks struggling to be “born” from the earth and the cliffs, only to turn into stone at the last moment of their growth. On some of these black, monstrous rocks, one could even see claw-like shapes, almost-formed tentacles, and even eye sockets and mouth-and-nose structures. Once they noticed these details, even someone as seasoned as Vanna, an experienced Inquisitor, could not help but frown. The eerie horror seemed to seep into her bones and made her extra wary.

The flowing fog seeped into every gap and also filled this deathly still valley.

“These rocks feel alive to me…” a squad member in a black robe, bearing the triangular Holy Emblem of the God of Death, muttered quietly. “Like

some kind of living things, sealed inside these black shells… I keep feeling like they might move at any moment."

"Control your imagination. Don't casually paint that kind of image in your mind." The God of Death priest who came from the Rest, and who had barely spoken a word since they landed, cut off his soldier's muttering at once.

Duncan glanced at this silent, strange priest of the God of Death. He was a tall, bald man, wearing a black robe. All the skin that showed outside his clothes was covered in dense, complex black rune tattoos. Those countless runes even climbed all the way over his eyelids. It made the priest look strange, gloomy, and frightening.

Because of the awkward tension that still existed between the Death Church and the Vanished, this leading priest did not talk much with Duncan along the way. But when he noticed Duncan looking at him, the odd-looking bald man still turned his head and nodded politely: "Is there something you wish to ask?"

"I remember your name is Norm," Duncan said with a nod. "After the Frostholm incident ended, a large amount of elements collected from Frostholm's pipe system was sent to the Death Church headquarters. Do you know about that?"

"I had direct contact with those samples," Norm answered casually. "They left a deep impression."

"What do you think of these 'traces' on this island?"

"…They share the same source, but they feel different to me," Norm said after thinking for a moment. His face looked a bit stiff as he answered, but he still spoke seriously. "The 'samples' from Frostholm were a cold and

disgusting substance. They were in a completely still state, with no more changes happening. But here…"

He paused and bent down to pick up a small stone from the ground.

"Others might not see it from the surface, but I can feel that… the inside is still 'working'. It is still undergoing slow 'changes'. It's hard to describe. It is a sense only we believers of the God of Death can feel. If I have to put it into words… it is like what Miss Shirley said. This whole island is 'alive'. Even though it has grown quiet again, every part of it is still 'living', only in a state that is close to death."

Duncan nodded slightly and stayed silent for a moment.

From the intelligence they already had, the entire island was formed from the power of the Abyssal Lord. And from what Shirley had seen in those "visions", it could even be considered a piece of "flesh" torn from the body of the Abyssal Lord. If it was truly the flesh of Elder Gods, then it was not hard to imagine that it could remain alive even after being separated from the main body for tens of thousands of years.

The only thing that felt unbelievable was… that it had evolved into this form at the edge of the Mortal Realm—trees, rocks, soil, streams flowing through the ravines, and all kinds of resources and minerals that could be collected on the island.

The Annihilators had even used the island's resources to build towns and harbors.

This made Duncan think. What kind of "being" was this so-called Abyssal Lord? Before it became one of the Elder Gods in the age of the Deep Sea, what had the core of "Navigator One", labeled LH-01, actually been?

And what about Rahm, the God of Wisdom, who also had an LH number and should be called "Navigator Two"? He seemed completely different

from the Abyssal Lord, both in power and in “form”… What lay behind that difference? Why did LH-01 and LH-02 differ so much?

For some reason, Duncan felt he was still overlooking something. Besides the numbers LH-01 and LH-02, there seemed to be another question he had never paid attention to…

But his thoughts did not go on.

Shirley, who was leading the way, suddenly slowed down.

“…I ‘saw’ this place before,” she said, blinking as she stood in an open space strewn with gravel. She looked around the misty valley, recalling the scenes from the chaotic visions in her mind. “Those cultists all gathered in this clearing. When the Sun went out, they crowded here, shouting like crazy. They thought they had been ‘enlightened’… Their dumb-ass dig site should be somewhere nearby… This used to be a sealed place. For some reason they never dared come close before. But when the Sun went out, they all lost their minds and stopped being afraid…”

Standing near Shirley, Amber frowned a little.

The young official of the Goddess turned her head toward Vanna: “…I think I just heard Miss Shirley say something very rude without even thinking about it…”

“You only just noticed?” Vanna looked surprised. “She’s always like that.”

Amber: “…?”

Shirley paid no attention to their chat at all. Her focus was completely drawn by the broken memory fragments constantly surfacing in her mind and the strong feeling of familiarity from the valley. She took two steps forward, and the blood-red glow in her eyes swept slowly across the thin fog. Very soon, she sensed a familiar aura coming from ahead.

The aura of the Abyssal Deep.

“This way.” She blinked. The blood-red light faded from her eyes. She raised her hand at once and pointed toward a narrow gap between two cliffs. “They dug down from here!”

It was a rock crack wide enough for two people to walk side by side. It seemed to have been a natural fracture in the canyon, but deeper inside there were clear signs of human excavation and widening. A few digging tools lay scattered around the entrance, but the ones who had used them had already been swallowed clean by the rocks and soil. Those chisel marks were the last proof that they had once existed in this world.

“…The passage below is narrow, and we don’t know what’s down there. We shouldn’t all go in,” Amber said after craning her neck to glance inside. She quickly pulled back and turned to the others. “I suggest most people make camp around the entrance. A small group of elites can go down to check the situation.”

“I’ll take the first team down,” Duncan said at once. “Alice, Shirley, Dog… and Morris—you four come with me. Vanna, you and Amber and Norm stay outside to make camp and keep watch on the island.”

There was good reason for his plan. One of his goals in coming to Sanctum Isle was to confirm what connection, if any, existed between Alice and the Abyssal Lord. So of course he had to bring the doll. Shirley and Dog would be their guides once they went below. Morris was very learned and also an experienced explorer of secret realms. This kind of mission was exactly his field.

But clearly Vanna had other ideas: “You’re not taking me? You might run into enemies down there. You’ll need extra fighting strength…”

“There might be enemies outside too,” Duncan said. Then he leaned forward and peeked into the crack at the cramped space below. He turned back and looked at Vanna with a serious face. “And it’s very low down there. No room to jump.”

Vanna froze, stunned for two or three seconds, before she reacted. She looked a bit awkward: “…I don’t only know that one move…”

But she only muttered that, and soon nodded: “Alright, I understand. We’ll stay here and make camp, and we’ll also do a basic search of the other parts of the valley.”

Duncan nodded lightly: “Good. Keep in touch. If anything happens, call my name at once.”

“Yes, Captain.”

Then Duncan led Morris, Alice, Shirley, and Dog toward the dark entrance that slanted down into the depths.

Vanna watched their figures vanish into the darkness. Only when she saw faint ghostly green flame light appear deeper in the passage did she quietly let out a breath. Then she turned her head and saw Amber standing nearby, staring straight at her with a strange look on her face.

Vanna felt a little awkward: “…Why are you looking at me like that?”

Amber thought for a moment, then could not hold back: “…Under normal circumstances, if something happens, aren’t you supposed to call the Goddess’s name first?”

Vanna’s expression went blank: “…”

The Inquisitor fell into deep thought.

But she soon recovered and looked at the younger junior in front of her with utter seriousness: “You can call both at the same time.”

This time it was Amber’s turn to stare blankly: “…You can?”

“You can.”

“…The Goddess allows it?”

Vanna spoke with pious certainty: “I asked, and He did not object.”

Amber kept staring, stunned: “…?”

Norm stood next to the two of them, his face unreadable (mostly because all his features were covered in tattoos). After a long time, he silently traced the triangular emblem of the God of Death over his chest and let out a long sigh that no one noticed.

At the same time, in the narrow passage that slanted ever downward, Shirley and Dog were moving forward with great care.

ghostly green flame slowly spread along the rock walls on both sides, lighting the path ahead. Shirley held the chain that linked her to Dog in one hand and steadied herself on the cold, smooth stone with the other. Her face was tense.

A faint blood-red glow shimmered at the bottom of her eyes.

Chapter 716: Crossing of Real and Unreal

From the entrance, the passage first ran downward along a narrow, low slope. Rough tool marks showed clearly on the surrounding rock walls. But after they walked more than ten meters, the passage ahead began to widen, and the slope grew a little gentler.

ghostly green fire spread along the rocks. Its glow lit the way ahead. Duncan looked at the corridor stretching on into the darkness, and his brow slowly furrowed.

“Did those cultists dig all of this in just a few days after the Sun went out?” Duncan could not help looking at Shirley as he asked: “In such a short time, they dug a passage this deep?”

“No. They only dug open the entrance to this passage, and then broke through the stones at the very bottom,” Shirley shook her head. “This stretch under our feet seems to have already been here before…”

“A passage that already existed deep under this ‘Holy Land Island’?” Morris frowned at once. He walked to the rock wall ahead, studied the stone around them and the ground under his feet, then spoke in a thoughtful tone: “So before those cultists found this place, someone else had already been digging here…”

He suddenly stopped talking and frowned in confusion. A moment later he slowly lifted his head and looked along the path lit by the faint green flame.

“No. It doesn’t look like something dug by people… This ‘original passage’ was made by something else…”

Duncan stepped forward when he heard that and asked: “What did you find?”

“Look at the marks on these rock layers,” Morris raised his hand and pointed at the walls around them. “These smooth, rolling fractures and the ring patterns spaced so evenly along the rock… They don’t look man-made.”

Duncan at once noticed the strange traces on the rock walls that Morris had mentioned.

He saw that the walls of the corridor ahead were smooth. The black and gray stone looked hard, as if some sharp thing had sliced all of it at once, leaving a continuous, clean shape. Every three meters or so, a raised ring of stone wrapped all the way around the passage. The floor under his feet was flat and gently sloped. Large and small stones were fitted together as if someone had carved them with great care and set them into the slope with no gaps at all.

These were not marks that the cultists’ tools or their demons’ spells could have made. They were clearly not the “results of excavation” by anyone before them either.

Even the city-states of today had no underground digging or building skills like this.

Morris slowly ran his fingers along the smooth rock walls on both sides and muttered under his breath: “We’re walking inside a huge pipe…”

“…Back then, under Frostholm, some parts of the Great Hollow also looked like this,” Duncan said in a low voice. “In the end, the scholars in the city-state could not explain how those smooth, flat fractures were formed. They

could only say they were ‘corruption hollows’ left behind after the flesh of the Abyssal Lord faded away. But this Holy Land Island… the whole thing is a piece of the Abyssal Lord. So why would there be ‘corruption hollows’ inside it?”

Shirley had been listening to Morris and the captain talk. Suddenly a wild thought flashed through her mind: “…Maybe this is the Abyssal Lord’s rectum?”

The moment she said that, everything went silent. Duncan and Morris both went even darker in the face than Shirley’s ghostly light. Duncan glared hard at the young lady: “You could at least say it’s a blood vessel!”

Shirley shrank her neck without thinking. She scratched her hair and tried to act calm as she changed the subject: “A blood vessel also seems pretty likely, heh…”

Duncan did not keep arguing with Shirley. After he blurted out that last sentence, he fell into thought again and frowned.

A blood vessel… an internal pipe?

If this Holy Land Island really was, as Shirley had said, a “piece of an Elder Gods’ body,” then would this piece of flesh truly have “blood vessels” and “nerves” inside it? If it did… would they really look like this “passage” in front of him?

Duncan followed that line of thought without meaning to. In his mind he tried to picture what kind of shape the Abyssal Lord might have, what kind of “body structure” it might hold. Just then, he suddenly noticed that Alice had not said a word for a long time.

Normally, when the doll young lady followed the captain into some strange new place, she would chatter nonstop. But today she was unusually quiet.

“Alice.” Duncan felt something was off. He at once looked at the doll standing beside him, who seemed a bit lost in thought, and asked: “What are you thinking about?”

He had to call her twice before Alice suddenly jolted as if waking from a dream. She turned her head in a hurry: “Eh… huh? Captain, what did you say?”

“I asked what you were thinking—just now you seemed to be spacing out the whole time.” Duncan frowned slightly. He looked into Alice’s eyes with some worry. “Did you see or hear something again?”

Alice looked around in confusion. She hesitated for quite a while before she finally answered Duncan very carefully: “I haven’t seen anything yet… But I don’t know why. After we walked here, I suddenly felt… very familiar.”

Duncan and Morris spoke at the same time: “A familiar feeling?”

“Yes. Familiar, safe, like…” Alice waved her hands for a long time before she finally found the right words. “Like lying inside my wooden box.”

As she spoke, she lifted her hand and pointed into the darker depths of the corridor: “And in that direction, the familiar feeling is even stronger. It’s like… I came to this place a long time ago, or… I stayed here for a very long time…”

Duncan listened to Alice’s description with a serious face. After a moment he nodded lightly: “We’ll keep going deeper. Alice, Shirley, Dog, no matter what strange thing you see or hear, tell me right away.”

With growing caution in their hearts, the group started walking farther into the passage that seemed to have no end.

The flames spread slowly along the corridor. After they walked for an unknown length of time, Duncan noticed that the space around them suddenly grew wider.

They seemed to have entered a huge underground cavity. The pipe-like passage on both sides suddenly opened out into broad rock walls. The ceiling above rose to more than ten meters in height. For a moment, the suddenly widened space fell into darkness. But after only a second or two, ghost-green flame raced out over the ground and began to light this wide place.

Shirley tipped her head back, staring in amazement at this underground cavern that looked like a huge hall for gatherings. Even though she had caught a quick glimpse of it in the “illusion” before, she still could not help gasping when she saw it with her own eyes: “…Holy crap…”

“…Now I suddenly think Vanna could come too,” Duncan rubbed his chin, lost in thought. “This place looks big enough for her to jump in as well…”

Morris said nothing. The old scholar’s attention was already fully taken by this strange cave full of secrets. He walked slowly along the path lit by the spirit flame, studying his surroundings with care. Then he suddenly stopped in front of a rock wall.

“There’s something on this wall!”

Duncan hurried over, and a scene like a “relief carving” came into view.

On the dark stone wall, a creature with strong limbs, a long body, and a crawling pose seemed almost alive.

Shirley and Dog followed close behind. They stood with Duncan, staring at the “relief” on the wall.

After quite a while, Duncan finally heard Shirley mutter in a low voice: “… Is that a Abyssal Hound?”

“It kind of is…” Dog’s voice sounded very unsure. “But it doesn’t look much like me… This one seems to have flesh, and the body’s proportions aren’t right…”

Before it finished speaking, Morris called again from ahead: “There’s more over here!”

Following Morris’s lead, Duncan saw a second relief.

This one showed a creature floating in midair, shaped like a jellyfish. But it was not made of smoke and dust. It had a solid body, more delicate tentacles, and even on its “head” there seemed to be organs that looked like eyes.

Duncan slowly lifted his head. In the glow of the spirit flame, more reliefs appeared in bits and pieces, set into the rock walls of the cavern. They seemed to stretch on without end at the edge of his sight.

He frowned a little and stepped toward another relief—

A trembling gleam appeared at the edge of his vision.

Duncan stopped at once.

At almost the same moment, the light and shadow before his eyes changed.

Everything suddenly turned into collapsing, scattered fragments of light. The dark cavern and the ancient, mysterious reliefs fell apart in silence before him. In the next instant, the falling shards of light swirled back together, gathered, reshaped, lit up, and appeared again—

In a soundless “roar,” he saw a hall. A hall that seemed to have no end. It formed itself with a rush before Duncan’s eyes.

He saw some silver-gray substance of unknown make spread through his view and turn into a solid floor. Dark blue glowing lines of some mysterious pattern ran all across that floor. High above, the dome blazed with lights. Huge pipes and cables crossed and twisted over the dome like nerves and blood vessels.

Inside this hall stood one round platform after another.

Those platforms gave off a faint glow. Above each one, some invisible field seemed to hang in the air, holding many things frozen in stillness. There were strong, four-legged hound-like creatures, hunting beasts, all kinds of birds, and many shapes he did not know at all and could not see clearly.

The light before his eyes flickered. The lamps in the hall dimmed and brightened. In the blink of an eye, Duncan felt as if he saw the dark cavern again, and the neat rows of “reliefs” on the rock walls—

But in the next second, the dim cavern collapsed again into the form of that hall. He saw something standing at the far end ahead. It was like a huge machine, or some kind of… terminal. Countless pipes gathered around a complex prismatic structure. In the pipes flowed a metallic, black sludge. Lights flashed on the prism that served as the core. Something like a holographic image floated in front of it, lines of text refreshing over and over.

The letters were strange. Duncan did not know that writing at all—but with just one glance, the meaning of the words seemed to sink straight into his mind—

“…the New Hope… main system offline…

“LH-01, Navigator One, ecosystem reconstruction mainframe… status: anomaly.

“LH-02, Navigator Two, data and master-control mainframe… status: anomaly.

“LH-03, Navigator Three, Navigation Mainframe… offline.

“Starship has disintegrated…”

—

Chapter 717: Fracture

The light and shadow collapsed again with a roar. The wide hall and the huge device at its far end broke apart into countless shards of light. Like an avalanche, they fell back into the shape of the dark cavern. It all felt like a short dream, another Mortal Realm casting a confused projection into this layer of reality.

But Duncan knew he had really “seen” it. And he knew he could still see it now.

He looked into the depths of the dim cavern and blinked a few times. In each extremely brief instant, each time his eyelids closed and darkness came, he could see something appear for a split second. It was that vast hall.

He slowly realized that two Mortal Realms were stacked together here, deep under this Holy Land Island. The “Mortal Realm” that lay one layer deeper could not be seen by normal means. But it appeared during 0.002 seconds of every blink of his eyes.

For no clear reason, the number “0.002 seconds” rose up in Duncan’s mind. He was sure it was the exact length of time he saw that hall each time he blinked. It was a moment almost too short for the human eye to catch, but it was enough to shine upon his senses.

He turned his head and looked at the “relief” on the wall beside him. At the next blink, he saw a vivid bird-like creature appear inside a sample containment tank. Then the darkness rose up, the Mortal Realms switched,

and it turned back into the relief on the wall. It was a twisted, savage "death-omen bird."

Alice seemed to notice the change in Duncan's expression. She grew worried at once: "Captain? Are you all right…? Your face suddenly got really serious…"

"…LH-01 could not send everything in its database into the Sanctuary World. The things that failed to form during the Genesis Protocol stayed in the first 'hatchery'," Duncan suddenly said in a soft voice. "…This Sanctuary World should have been bigger and more complete. But it failed…"

Morris stared at Duncan in shock. Then he suddenly reacted: "You touched something?"

"There's another shape overlaid on this place. It is how things looked before the Great Annihilation… But you can't see it or touch it," Duncan raised his hand and pressed it lightly to the rock wall beside him. As the ghost-green spirit flame spread into the cracks, he could faintly feel that he was touching more than just cold stone. "Two Mortal Realms are stacked here. The one closer to the original form has been almost completely eaten away by the Great Annihilation. It can only exist briefly during each blink of my eyes."

Morris struggled to understand this impossible "state" that Duncan described. By now, Duncan had already lifted his head and was looking toward the deeper part of the cavern.

"There should be a 'contact point' here," Duncan said in a low voice. "Those cultists must have triggered something in this place."

As he spoke, he stepped into the darkness. With the slow spread of the faint green flames, he walked toward where the "hall" ended.

Morris and Alice at once followed behind their captain.

…

Dog walked with his head low in some tired silence beside Shirley. The blood-red glow in his eye sockets flickered on and off. The scraping of chains over the ground sounded like a distant noise. He walked forward a while longer, then lifted his head a bit late—and found that Shirley had already gone far ahead.

The girl’s back looked blurry. The edges of her figure kept shaking, as if something unstable was overlaid on her body.

Dog shook his head. His empty skull seemed to lose the ability to think and judge for a brief moment. In the next instant, he snapped awake and found that he was, as usual, walking right beside Shirley. The scene where the two of them had drifted far apart felt like a strange illusion that vanished in a blink.

Shirley lowered her head in mild confusion and saw Dog walking at her side.

Then she felt a stabbing pain in her arm. A burning sensation flowed along the chain of the symbiotic pact into her, like… freshly spilled blood.

“Dog?” she whispered. She was not sure if she had spoken out loud or if she only called through the symbiotic pact link in her heart.

Dog did not answer. What reached Shirley’s ears were only two sounds: “thump, thump.”

They sounded like heartbeats.

Something was wrong… She did not know what was wrong, but something was definitely wrong!

Shirley’s whole body tensed at once. The moment she sensed that something was off, she reacted. She snapped her head up and looked toward the captain: “Captain! Dog is—”

There was no sign of the captain ahead.

In the dark cavern, only her own voice echoed back to her. It quickly faded into a vague noise. The captain was gone. Morris and Alice were gone too. Only she and Dog were here, as if it had been only the two of them from the very beginning.

Shirley drew in a sharp breath. The vast, endless darkness turned into an even greater fear. This fear was so familiar. She had thought that she had forgotten this bone-deep feeling, but now it all leaped back into her mind at once—

Fire. Smoke. The smell of blood. The sound of something collapsing. The feeling of something chewing on her flesh…

In the darkness, she stared with wide, terrified eyes. Bone-like spikes slowly pushed out from her arms, shoulders, and spine. Blood-red light filled her eyes and made everything in her sight twist and warp. In that ever more twisted sense of the world, she heard a somewhat unfamiliar voice suddenly come from her side: “Shirley… I feel… kind of cold…”

She slowly turned her head and looked toward the source of the voice.

Dog was sinking. He was sinking into the soil and rock, as if he were melting. His body was slowly swallowed by the ground. The ground seemed to come alive. Thick, slow ripples spread across its surface. It was as if countless living things were hidden inside those ripples. Dog’s body sank into those “living things” bit by bit. First his legs, then his body. Soon only his neck and part of his skull were left.

He opened his mouth toward Shirley. The bony jaws opened and shut. He seemed to be speaking with great effort, or trying hard to spit something out —

“Dog!!!”

Her numb and stiff mind finally started to move. Shirley suddenly remembered the name at the other end of the chain. She rushed toward that patch of ground that was slowly turning alive. She grabbed the chain on her arm with all her strength and shouted: “Dog! I’ll pull you out! Hold on!”

But no matter how hard she tried, she could not stop Dog from sinking. Just as the Abyssal Hound’s skull was about to be swallowed completely by the thick mud, a voice suddenly came into her ears.

“…Shirley, your dad and I are going to buy you a cake. Today is your birthday… When we get back, you won’t be mad at us anymore, all right?”

The girl froze for a moment.

The voice from the other end of the chain cut her reason for a brief instant. At that same instant, she heard a clear snapping sound.

Her hand suddenly felt light.

The Abyssal Hound vanished completely into the mud. The heavy pull from the end of the chain disappeared at once. Shirley stumbled backward.

She saw the other end of the chain whip out of the mud. It had broken. There was no familiar Dog at the broken end. Only two fist-sized things had been flung out with it and landed one after another beside her.

They thumped on the ground, over and over, as if they were still alive.

They were two hearts.

Shirley stared at the scene in a daze, as motionless as a statue.

The pitch-black mud began to churn slowly and gather from all directions. In the mud, a vision of some far-off place seemed to form. Innumerable twisted, savage shadows drifted all around—

In the Abyssal Deep Sea, countless demons noticed an uninvited guest drawing close to their dimension.

Farther out in the darkness, a huge structure lay asleep. Its body sprawled like a mountain across broken land. Its coiling tendrils wrapped around countless floating islands. Dim blue light flowed across its surface. From those tendrils, demons were born without end, and every moment it devoured them again.

But Shirley seemed not to see those looming visions. She sat on the ground in a daze for a while, then slowly got up and crawled toward the two hearts that were still beating. She carefully picked them up and held them in her arms.

She had not held them for a very long time.

“Dad… Mother…”

Darkness surged in. Her figure vanished into the Abyssal Deep Sea.

…

Duncan suddenly turned his head and looked toward a patch of open ground not far behind them.

A blurry figure flickered there for a moment and vanished in a blink.

He reacted at once: “Something happened to Shirley!”

“Shirley?!” Morris, walking behind Duncan, froze for a second. In that brief moment, he even forgot the name “Shirley.” The captain’s words snapped his memory back into the right “place.” Only then did he look up, a step

late, and realize that one person was missing from the group… and one Abyssal demon as well.

“Hey! She was just walking right next to me!” Alice also came to her senses now. She stared wide-eyed at the spot where Shirley and Dog had been. “I even heard her talking to Dog…”

Duncan’s face grew grim at once: “None of you noticed when she disappeared?”

Morris and Alice both shook their heads.

Duncan’s brow tightened. After a very short moment of thought, he swept his hand hard through the air.

ghostly green flames of spirit form flared up in an instant. With a string of explosions that rose almost to a roar, the fire howled like a storm and rushed into every corner of the cavern!

The roaring flames seemed to shake time and space itself. The whole cavern, even the whole Holy Land Island, shuddered hard in that instant. After this quake that seemed to shake the very dimension, Duncan’s face had already turned very dark.

“The marks on Shirley and Dog are both still there,” he lifted his head and said to Morris in a heavy tone. “…But they have split apart.”

Chapter 718: Falling Into the Abyssal Deep

In the valley at the heart of Sanctuary Island, Vanna was leading the team and setting up camp at the tunnel entrance when she received news from the cave. She stared in shock and blurted out: “Shirley and Dog are gone?”

“Strictly speaking, they were ‘shifted’ somewhere else by some kind of space-time mechanism in the cave,” Duncan’s voice sounded in Vanna’s mind. “Have you seen any changes on the surface?”

“No. Everything on the surface is normal. Amber just led a team to search the depths of the valley. They found nothing but a few empty huts and some human remains that had been half swallowed by the island,” Vanna answered at once. “The island is very quiet right now…”

Deep in the underground cavern, Duncan nodded slightly after hearing Vanna’s report from the surface. Then his gaze fell on Morris and Alice nearby.

“The surface is normal. Sanctuary Island has not shown any signs of ‘coming alive’. It seems what happened to Shirley and Dog is not the same as what happened to those Annihilators.”

“Then where did they go?” Alice asked anxiously. “Didn’t you say you could still feel their ‘mark’? Are they safe now?”

“They are still alive, but they are in a place I cannot pinpoint. I suspect…”

Duncan stopped halfway. He did not rush to a conclusion, but it was clear he already had a guess in his heart. After a brief silence, he raised his head and looked thoughtfully toward the depths of the cavern.

In the drowsy darkness, a vast shape seemed to stand there in the distance.

Every time he blinked, a huge prism appeared there, wrapped in many cables and pipes. Lights flashed across its surface, as if sending out a silent invitation.

He walked over and let his flame drive back the darkness. In the light of the spirit flame, a grand gate stood in silence, as if it had been set directly into the rock walls on both sides.

On the open ground around the gate lay many tools scattered in haste. In the floor and nearby walls, human shapes were half fused into the stone and soil, melted until no details remained. They looked twisted and horrific.

There was no doubt this was the “final chamber” Shirley had mentioned, the last excavation site deep under Sanctuary Island, the place where those Annihilators had finally “woken” the whole island.

Duncan came to the gate and quickly examined its structure by firelight. The black stone door was tightly shut. Its surface was rough and uneven, as if vines had once covered it and had now rotted away, leaving only a chaos of pits and grooves. In that messy, almost patternless web of lines, Duncan still faintly made something out.

They were the strange characters he had seen in that “hall”, the symbols he had seen before in the vision of the New Hope’s crash.

He frowned slightly, but before he could read the message hidden in the lines, Alice, who stood beside him, broke the silence in a small voice: “Navigator One… access interface?”

Duncan turned his head at once and looked at the doll craning her neck to study the gate: “You can read what is written on this door?”

Alice frowned and slowly shook her head: “I don’t see any writing on the door… It just suddenly popped into my head…”

Duncan stared into Alice’s eyes. His thoughts raced, then he drew back his gaze and turned to the gate again. After a few seconds of hesitation and thinking, he placed his hand on the stone and closed his eyes a little, gathering his mind.

ghostly green flame spread from his fingertips and flashed across the door, then vanished.

In his other sight, in a distant, dark, and strange dimension, a tiny spark suddenly flickered as if stirred by wind. Deep in the darkness, it swayed and flashed once.

In that weak, swaying fire, Duncan heard Shirley’s voice. It was clearer than before, but still separated from him by a thick layer of the Veil.

She was very scared. She was very cold. She had just lost something important. She was carefully building a shell of self-protection around herself, while something with ill intent gathered around her.

Duncan opened his eyes.

“Lucy.” He called in his heart to the witch waiting on the Radiant Star.

Lucretia’s voice came at once: “Do you need me?”

“Bring that Saint over. I have found the ‘connection point’,” Duncan said. “Now I need to open a door and go into the Abyssal Deep Sea, to bring them back.”

“Understood.”

The voice in his mind faded. Duncan slowly raised his right hand. In his palm, a ball of fire was forming, unusually bright, bright enough to sting the eyes.

He pressed the fire onto the black stone door and watched it slowly seep into the gate, then into that strange, dark dimension behind it. Before the flame vanished completely, he spoke softly to it: "…Shirley, don't be afraid."

…

It was very dark. It was very cold. Her body felt as heavy as if it were filled with lead. A strange sharp pain spread from her arm, up to her shoulder, then to half of her body. The pain slowly changed into numbness, as if this body no longer belonged to her, as if her flesh had quietly turned into something she could neither understand nor control.

The "swamp" around her had faded at some unknown time, but an even stronger sense of malice and danger kept rising from all directions. Shirley curled up deep inside a "thicket" that twisted together like broken bones. She hid there without moving.

Mad howls and rambling whispers came from far away. Invisible hunters were prowling in the dark, searching for the uninvited guests who had entered this place. The hunters' presence was slowly drawing near. It was only a matter of time before the "prey" was found.

But this time there was no Abyssal Hound to protect her.

Shirley hugged her twisted, deformed arm even tighter and shrank deeper into the thicket. She had already "smelled" the air here and figured out where she was.

This was the Abyssal Deep Sea. It was Dog's "homeland".

It was the lair of demons.

The faint sound of “thump, thump” beat by her ears. The pulse rising from her chest pulled Shirley out of her daze. She lowered her head in a trance and looked at the two hearts she held in her arms.

“Dad… Mother…”

She muttered softly, just like when she had refused to sleep as a child, hiding in her bed to whisper to “them”.

“I am a bit scared… I want to hold you…”

The two hearts still beat slowly. The sound of thump, thump was so clear. For many years they had been beating inside the body of a Abyssal demon. Behind thick bones and swirling black smoke, their beating had never sounded so clear to Shirley.

Shirley clenched her arms a little tighter, and the feeling in her hands seemed wrong.

She lowered her head and saw a pair of arms covered in a thin layer of bone armor. Blade-like structures stretched out from her elbow joints, slowly opening and closing like living things. Then she looked at her chest.

There was a terrifying hollow there. Inside the hollow was a skeleton surrounded by rising black smoke. A damaged dark red organ beat with difficulty among the bones and smoke, growing weaker with every passing second.

In a human body, this damaged organ was called a “heart”.

“…So my heart was bitten open by Dog back then… No wonder it is so cold…”

Shirley spoke in a low voice as she shifted her position a little in the thicket. She saw that her legs were also slowly being covered by a layer of strange

black bone plates. Smoke that marked Abyssal Deep corruption kept rising from the plates and spreading into the air.

She felt more and more sleepy.

Would she die in the form of a Abyssal demon? Or had she already been a Abyssal demon wearing human skin ever since twelve years ago, when Dog fused with her?

This brief thought rose in Shirley’s mind for no reason, but soon even that thought faded in the heavy drowsiness.

She did not want to think about this, and she could not think about this.

She did not understand such things. These “deep” questions were too hard for her.

She cared more about water, food, fuel for the fire, and warm clothes for winter.

The roars and whispers grew closer. The hunters in the dark were drawing near this borderland. Their swelling and shrinking shapes cast even darker shadows in the darkness. A chilling touch seemed to reach her skin a step ahead of them.

But her body was already slowly tipping over. Even the two still beating hearts could no longer wake her from the strong sleepiness. Inside her broken chest, the heart that demons had chewed was slowly beginning its last beat.

A warm light rose in the darkness, as if a ray of gentle sunlight shone on her face. Shirley narrowed her eyes a little and let out a relaxed, content sigh.

It was a warm winter afternoon.

sunlight streamed in through the window and fell on a wooden sill with peeling paint. The kettle on the stove gave a happy hiss. Mother was busy in

the kitchen, and the smell of baking biscuits drifted into the sitting room. Dad did not have to work today. He was crouched by the dining table, trying to fix the boards that always creaked. From the street came the clear bell of the postman's bicycle as he crossed the corner and the sound of carriage wheels rolling over the cobblestones.

Shirley dozed on the sofa and was about to fall asleep.

Then Dad would come over. He would pick her up and carry her to the bed in her room. Mother would come out of the kitchen and tap Dad on the head with a long-handled ladle, because his dirty hands had smudged their Daughter's dress…

Lying on the sofa, Shirley slowly showed a faint smile, just like that afternoon many years ago. She rolled over a little. Her arm slipped from the back of the sofa onto her own body and curled against her chest.

Her hand touched a heart that had stopped beating.

All the warmth collapsed at once. Darkness and cold tore through that gentle afternoon sunlight like an avalanche. In the darkness Shirley's eyes flew wide open. When the roar of fear rushed in, she saw the figure that had been crouching by the dining table slowly stand up and walk toward her.

That figure changed in the flames and burned everything in the dark.

"Shirley, don't be afraid."

Chapter 719: Both Sides of the Gate

Shirley’s mind snapped awake from the collapsing dream. She opened her eyes in the darkness and saw that she was still lying in that black thicket that looked like a tangle of thorns.

Whispers and strange howls sounded as if they were already at her ears, almost boring into her head. Cold currents crept from the gaps in the shadows like disgusting tendrils, as if they meant to lick her skin. There was something outside the thicket, a swarm of writhing things whose size kept changing, their real shapes hard to see. They had smelled living flesh and had crossed a long distance to find this hiding place. A gluttonous feast was about to begin.

Shirley twitched her arm a little. The stiffness and numbness in her whole body made every movement painfully hard, but she felt a faint heat spreading from somewhere inside her, once more feeding this shell that had just died.

She lowered her head with effort and saw that the heart in her chest had completely stopped beating. In just a few seconds it had shriveled into a lump of black residue. Yet on that residue, a thin strand of ghostly green flame burned quietly. It was eerie, but it felt warm.

Within this small warmth she got back a little strength and slowly struggled to sit up.

When her arm swung by accident, the broken black chain on her right wrist scraped across the ground. The sound was not loud, but in this silent darkness it was sharp as a shout.

The whispers and howls outside the thicket paused for a moment, then suddenly rose into a chilling roar.

Countless rising and falling shadows surged up from the shattered ground outside. In wild joy, countless Abyssal demons took shape and rushed toward the feast.

spirit flame spread and burned in the gaps between her bones. The black residue in her chest had fully turned into a small, steady flame. Shirley took a deep breath. She heard the noise from outside. Fear of death and a restless, nameless urge rose together in her mind. She panted softly, and from the corner of her eye she saw the two hearts that had fallen to the ground.

After a short hesitation, she reached out and picked up the two still beating “hearts”. Her eyes, glowing with a faint red light, flickered.

A cracking sound came from the edge of the thicket. A huge beast tore open the barrier of her hiding place. Heavy footsteps and hungry growls reached Shirley’s ears.

But she seemed not to hear the sound that was already above her head, nor to feel the breath that had blown upon her face. She only lowered her head and slowly pushed the two hearts into her own chest, murmuring as if talking to herself: “Dad… Mother… don’t be afraid…”

The feeling of a heartbeat returned to her chest. The sense of “being alive” made the last stiffness and slowness in her limbs finally fade away. Shirley pushed herself to her feet. A series of sharp cracking sounds exploded from

within her body. Along the edge of her black ribs, layers of bone spurs grew in a rush, wrapping the two hearts and the small flame in a bony cage.

She raised her head in the darkness. Her body stretched taller. A monstrous skull covered in spikes appeared in her field of view.

The thicket that had been her hiding place was torn open in a huge gap. A giant floating skull leaned forward in malice, peering down at the prey in the bushes. Around the skull circled countless horrifying shapes: Death-Omen Birds, Smokewisp Jellyfish, Mad Terrorbeasts…

Dog had once told her that if she ever ran into these things alone, she must run.

But this was the Abyssal Deep Sea. There was nowhere to run here. They were everywhere.

“Shirley, don’t be afraid…”

A Death-Omen Bird attacked first. This confused and half-witted demon could no longer restrain the hunger and violence in its instincts. It let out a sharp screech. Its wings suddenly spread into a dark cloud and plunged down at the thicket, wrapped in a mass of corrosive mist.

Then there was a heavy, dull sound of piercing. A black, jointed bone spike stabbed up like a sword and rammed straight through the Death-Omen Bird.

Next came spike after spike. Black bones, like twisted and symmetrical limbs, stretched out from the thicket. They first stabbed into the sky, then bent down, bracing a tall body that stepped out from among the branches.

Her limbs were long. Black bone plates covered them layer upon layer like tight armor, crossing and overlapping. Sharp bone spurs and blade-like shapes grew from the joints of her arms and legs, shining with a dim red gleam. Her broken chest was covered in jagged shards of bone like thorns. Inside the bone cage, two dark red hearts beat slowly. From her back,

countless limb-like bone structures stretched out, like a vast cloak of bone wings yet also like strange, ill-omened legs. These paired limbs bent down from the air and propped her body high above the ground, letting her look down on the Abyssal demons gathering from every direction.

She slowly turned her head. On the face that still kept a human shape, the hollow eyes filled with a rising red glow.

A hoarse, scratching screech sounded beside her. The Death-Omen Bird skewered on her bone spike thrashed a few times on Shirley's "long leg", then dissolved into a mass of quickly fading smoke and a small puddle of slow-flowing sludge. Bit by bit, it was drawn into Shirley's bone spike.

Shirley frowned a little as she watched the spot where the Death-Omen Bird faded away. She lifted that jointed limb and shook it hard in the air: "… Gross. Tastes bad…"

Then she turned her head toward the demons gathered around her. They were frozen in confusion for a moment by the sudden change. She bent forward a little and asked: "Have any of you seen a strange Abyssal Hound? Its name is Dog. He is my friend."

The Abyssal demon swarm drew back for a heartbeat. Some survival instinct made their dull minds think of retreat, but in only a moment, the urge to attack crushed that fragile "reason".

The strange floating skull covered in spikes suddenly opened its jaws. A huge cloud of corrosive mist formed at once and hurled straight toward Shirley.

Next came Death-Omen Birds swooping from the air, Abyssal Hounds racing and howling on the ground, and countless twisted monsters whose names even Shirley did not know. These Abyssal demons, who acted only

on instinct, rushed in all at once, roaring and howling as they charged in madness at the “intruders” in their territory.

“I knew it…”

Shirley grumbled in an annoyed tone. In the next second, her figure turned into a blurred shadow.

She swept across the shattered land like the wind. Those bone spikes, like giant skeletal wings and also like curved limbs, spread and stabbed through the air, striking at every demon that dared to come near. With no tactics and no knowledge of any spell, she relied only on the new instincts of her body and the most basic speed and strength as she plunged into the countless demon swarms.

It was a simple and brutal way to fight, just like the first time she had swung her chain and hurled Dog at her enemies.

…

Lucretia looked up at the black stone gate that was shocking even to her, a seasoned border scholar. It took her a long moment to look away.

“…They really did dig up something terrifying,” the sea witch sighed. “These cultists always make a mess they cannot control… as always.”

“This is the connection point between the Abyssal Deep Sea, and the Mortal Realm,” Duncan said beside her. “From what I can sense, several layers of dimension overlap here. Not only is Mortal Realm space and time stacked together, but part of the Abyssal Deep Sea, is also stacked directly on this spot. Shirley and Dog are probably so close in nature to the Abyssal Deep side that they simply ‘fell’ to the other side.”

Lucretia nodded, then spoke again with some worry: “…Are you sure this will work? I am not saying your power cannot open the gate, but… if that Saint cannot hold on and the gate closes too soon, how will you come back?

On the other side of the gate is the Abyssal Deep Sea. We know very little about it. Even you might be in danger if you get lost over there…"

"It is fine. I have thought about that," Duncan cut off Lucretia's worries. "We all know that at the very center of the Abyssal Deep Sea, lies the Abyssal Lord. Under His throne is the passage to Subspace."

Lucretia's expression turned a bit strange at once: "…You mean…"

"I only need to punch a small hole. It should not disturb the balance of the whole Abyssal Deep Sea. After all, the breach the Vanished smashed into the Abyssal Deep Sea back then was much larger," Duncan said casually. "If I cannot return the same way, I will come back from Subspace. That Lord should not mind too much. If that does not work, I can just call the Vanished and have them crash through again."

Lucretia: "…"

Duncan only waved his hand: "Let us begin."

Seeing that Father was ready, Lucretia said no more. She nodded lightly, then walked to the open ground in front of the gate. She pointed her short conductor's baton at the floor and tapped twice.

With a soft bang, a cloud of smoke puffed up like a stage magic trick. When the smoke cleared, the strange, disgusting "brain" wrapped in a spider-like bone cage appeared once more before Duncan.

The Saint slowly woke.

Along the edge of the bone cage, the many eye stalks stirred as if rousing from sleep. Its many eyeballs twitched and trembled, and at last it noticed its surroundings and the expressionless Duncan and his group standing beside it.

In almost an instant, this monster that could no longer be called human was fully awake. It strained to rise, but the bindings Lucretia had cast on it earlier held it completely still. It could only make the air around it shake as it let out a harsh and jumbled roar: “What have you done?!”

“We have not done anything yet. We are just about to start,” Duncan said as he stepped toward the Saint. He fixed his calm gaze on that disgusting forest of eye stalks. “You may begin your prayer now – to your master.”

Chapter 720: Open the Door

“Begin your prayer—to your Lord.”

The brain inside the skeletal crown suddenly convulsed. From that sentence alone, the Saint abruptly sensed enormous danger and terror—it did not know what this fear truly was, yet the warning sent by Dark Fate pressed on its subconscious like a great mountain.

It began to struggle violently. Its powerful will even broke through, for a brief moment, the layers of restraints the Witch had placed inside its body. The bone spurs at the edge of the skeletal cage started to rattle and clack. As the bindings loosened for that instant, its senses slowly returned. It finally noticed its surroundings—it sensed the familiar aura of Sacred Island.

It realized where it had been brought. In that moment, heavy despair wrapped its already crazed and warped mind layer by layer, like the veil of night.

“Holy Land!” The terrible brain swelled and shrank as it writhed. The air around it trembled as it roared in wild, overlapping voices: “Holy Land! You have defiled the Holy Land! You heretic cultists… the Lord will punish you, none of you will escape!”

Duncan and Lucretia only watched the raging Saint with expressionless faces. After a moment, Duncan finally raised his right hand. A flame burned in his palm, its edge flickering as thin streams of fire dripped to the ground. One stream spread toward the dark stone door, while another flowed in silence to the Saint’s feet and began to burn.

Only when the flame started spreading did Duncan break the silence: “Two things. First, your ‘Holy Land’ doesn’t need anyone else to defile it. Your foolish kin dug through the surface and woke the flesh of the Elder Gods. They have already ‘returned to the holy Lord’ just as they wished, in every sense of the phrase.”

“Second, I don’t care what your Lord thinks about all this. But I do have some things I want to discuss with your Lord. So, begin your prayer. This is probably the only time in your life you can truly help share the Abyssal Lord’s burden. And from a personal point of view… this will make what comes next a little easier on you.”

The fire spread. The pale green spirit form flame slowly climbed the huge dark stone door. The streams of fire seeped into the grooves on the door like water and burned across its surface, making the whole door seem to come alive, shivering and shaking as if it might move. Another branch of the flame ignited the Saint’s skeletal limbs and began to crawl across its whole body.

A fear that burned the soul along with the flesh swept through the monster’s mind. It struggled with all its strength, but the Witch’s restraints crushed all resistance in an instant. It could only watch the fire spread. Yet compared to the pain in its twisted body, another, darker “sensation” was what filled it with utter despair—

It felt itself forming a link with that dark stone door, a connection deeper and harder to understand than any physical touch. It felt itself slowly becoming part of that door, becoming part of the world behind it. Its consciousness, its memories, all of its reason and everything it could use to hold on to its “self” were turning into the door’s… data…

In a daze, a hollow voice echoed. It was a strange, low hum. On the crumbling edge of its consciousness, the Saint felt his personality stand up

again from that twisted, deformed body. He once more felt his hands and feet, the texture of breathing, the vibration of sound against his eardrums—those parts he had once willingly cast off, the parts that belonged to humans, seemed to return to the world in this illusion.

“Offer your prayer to your Lord…”

A voice boomed through his mind, making him raise his head in confusion and daze. But his subconscious still struggled. He clenched his teeth and tried to shake off the voice’s influence—yet it kept coming, trembling on all sides, trembling even inside his own subconscious—

“Offer your prayer to your Lord…”

He lifted his eyes in the darkness and saw a grand black gate standing before him, like the beginning and end of all things. The surface of the gate rippled and writhed like a pool of water. Between those shimmering ripples, he saw countless blurred and broken scenes—

He had once studied in the city-state. He had once hurried through streets and alleys, busy like an ordinary person. He had longed for many things, only to be swallowed by a greater emptiness the moment he got them. In wild indulgence he noticed how false the body’s shell was. In the baptism of blood he gained a brief “enlightenment”—he saw his first sacrifice, a small body lying quietly in a blood-draining trough, spasming one last time. He saw his final sacrifice, a ruined heap that no longer looked human, with only a pair of eyes left, filled with fear and despair. In those eyes was reflected a powerful body that had already surpassed mortal flesh…

And all of it was being swallowed by the black gate—everything about him as a human, everything inhuman, everything he had experienced, everything he had tried to escape… it was all being uploaded to the Source…

“Offer your prayer to your Lord.”

Beside the black gate, a giant filled with starlight looked down. The giant had no face. Many brilliant star-rivers flowed through its body. Dazzling star clusters and dim cloud belts outlined its unspeakable features. It bent down slightly. A river of stars stretched out like a tentacle and flowed to hover before the Saint’s eyes. The tip of that starry tendril opened in silence. Countless eyes blinked in the starlight, watching the Saint’s soul.

Beside the starlit giant, the black gate slowly opened. An existence with a towering main body like a high tower, wrapped in countless massive tentacles, cast a single glance toward the mortal world.

Why refuse your prayer? The Lord was right there… It cast down thousands upon thousands of merciful gazes.

Overwhelming emotion pried open the Saint’s heart. He finally forgot where he had come from. He forgot what he was supposed to do. Before that towering being, he bent his waist, then dropped to the ground and lay prostrate. He whispered softly: “My Lord…”

The ghostly green flame flared up. The dark stone door turned, in an instant, into a gently rippling, pitch-black mirror. Within the waves on that surface, one could faintly see a vast world deep inside.

Duncan turned his head and saw the shriveled black remains quietly burning on the open ground in front of the black gate. Its life had already faded, but the remains that were left… looked as if they could burn for a very long time.

“The Saint really is more fireproof than most.”

He sighed casually, then turned his gaze to the “black gate” that now rippled like a mirror. On the other side of the door, the auras of Shirley and Dog were still active, and growing clearer.

He stepped forward and touched the black mirror with his fingertips. The surface rippled, but he felt no sensation at his fingers.

It was like touching a phantom.

“Is this the door leading to the Abyssal Deep, to the Deep Sea?” Morris could not help but step closer. He studied the black gate with a frown as he spoke: “It looks… somewhat like the ‘rifts’ opened by Abyssal demons, but clearly much more stable…”

“In essence, it is a rift opened by Abyssal demons. That Saint had already become a Abyssal demon. Of course it had the ability to open a passage to the Abyssal Deep, to the Deep Sea,” Duncan said lightly. “All I did was force the rift to stabilize after it opened, and use the ‘connection point’ in this cave to anchor the door as close as possible to Shirley and Dog. Right now I can feel that the two of them are somewhere on the other side.”

As he spoke, he glanced at Alice beside him, then at Morris and Lucretia across from him. He already had a plan.

“Alice, you’re coming through the door with me. Morris and Lucy, you’ll stay outside.”

“You don’t need me to go in with you?” Lucretia asked at once, a bit worried.

“No.” Duncan shook his head. “I’m not going there to fight. I’m only going to find people and have a talk with the Abyssal Lord. Taking one more person or one less person won’t make much difference—but this side of the door needs a warden.”

He paused, thinking, then added: “This rift will stay open for quite a long time. Before we return, Abyssal demons will definitely notice this passage. At that point, things will come out through the door—so you and Morris have to guard this place. And it’s not just this door. The whole Sacred Island

could change because of this rift. So you also need to inform Vanna and the people of the Deep Sea and the Church of Death. From now until the door is closed, there may be a lot of ‘guests’ showing up around here.”

Listening to Father’s plan, Lucretia’s expression slowly grew serious. She nodded lightly: “I understand—Mr. Morris and I will guard this place.”

Duncan nodded and said nothing more. He only turned and beckoned to Alice.

“Hold on to me. Don’t let go halfway,” he said quietly to the doll who had followed him over.

Alice nodded at once and grabbed Duncan’s arm tightly. A smile appeared on her face. There was no trace of tension in that smile. In fact, she looked very happy, as if… she was not about to go to a place that would terrify any ordinary person, but was simply going on an outing with the captain.

“Not afraid?” Standing before the rippling black mirror, Duncan noticed the smile on Alice’s face and could not help asking softly.

Alice laughed with real joy: “I’m not afraid!”

“Good.”

Duncan nodded and, without any hesitation, led the doll straight through the black gate.

A strange sensation rushed over them.

It was as if they had passed through a layer of unreal fog. There was no resistance, no discomfort, only a faint, cool breath that rose and then faded in an instant. In that brief moment, it felt as though they had crossed an infinitely long tunnel in the blink of an eye—

Alice’s eyes widened in wonder. Clutching the captain’s arm, she saw many streams of light flashing past. But more surprising than those strange lights

was that she seemed to “hear” something.

As they passed through the “tunnel,” on their way to the other side, a voice entered her mind directly—

“Verifying identity, ?#@?&%&… pass.

“Verifying identity, LH-03, Navigator Three, pass.”

Chapter 721: Crossing the dome

That unreal, ethereal voice vanished at once, as if it had never existed.

In the dark “tunnel,” Alice blinked, puzzled by what she had just heard. She suspected she had misheard it, but…

The captain had said that in strange places like this, no matter what you heard or saw, you had to report it right away, even if it was just a hallucination.

So she quickly squeezed Duncan’s arm: “Captain, I just heard a voice!”

“A voice?” Duncan turned his head at once. In the darkness, he fixed his gaze on the doll’s eyes. “What voice?”

Alice immediately repeated what she had heard—including that short, unrecognizable burst of noise, and the strange “name” LH-03, “Navigator Three.”

In the dark, endless tunnel, Duncan slowly widened his eyes. He looked at the doll before him with a very strange, shocked expression, and then a trace of understanding suddenly rose in his gaze.

So that was it… it was like this?!

As a storm of tangled thoughts and staggering guesses surged through his mind, he understood many things in an instant. Almost at the same time, he noticed something bright and dense at the edge of his vision.

Still stunned, Duncan snapped his head around and looked toward where the light had appeared.

A second later, he saw the “Starry Sky” that lay on the dome above the Abyssal Deep, above the Deep Sea—

Magnificent starlight appeared at the end of the “tunnel.” It was a vast scene woven from thousands of stars, stellar nurseries, and high-energy radiation clouds. A river of stars crossed boundless darkness. A massive, erupting celestial body had been torn apart into glowing nebulae spread across the galaxy. All of it formed an endless, splendid Veil that swept into Duncan’s and Alice’s vision like a crashing tide.

Duncan’s eyes flew wide open.

This was the “Starry Sky” that every captain who sailed the Boundless Sea knew well. It lay between the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep Sea. Under normal conditions, one could only “look down” on it through complex Spirit Realm lenses, as a great Star Map. Seafarers in the mortal world could only cast cautious glances at it from behind thick lenses and layers of protection. But here, the truest face of this Starry Sky and every tiny detail of it appeared directly before his eyes.

Duncan and Alice “fell” faster toward that frozen Starry Sky. Pulled by an unseen force, they were quickly entering the dome layer above the Abyssal Deep, above the Deep Sea.

They plunged into the starlight and began to pass swiftly between those motionless celestial bodies.

After a brief hesitation, Duncan reached out toward the unfamiliar stars.

A bright orange-yellow star passed through his palm like a phantom. At the same time, tiny points of starlight appeared on his skin, yet the two clearly did not affect each other.

Then he suddenly noticed how quiet Alice was beside him. Normally, this doll would already be shouting and chattering at the sight of such a

magnificent Starry Sky.

But Alice only stared wide-eyed at the surroundings, as if something else had captured all of her attention. The brilliant lights were reflected in her deep purple eyes, dancing there with a lively gleam. After quite a while, the doll suddenly raised her hand and pointed in a direction, mumbling like someone talking in her sleep: “Coordinates offset.”

Duncan frowned: “What did you say?”

It was as if Alice had not heard the captain at all. She still kept her gaze on the stars around them, then lifted her hand again and pointed another way: “Coordinates offset.”

“Coordinates offset. Coordinates offset. Coordinates offset…”

Alice spoke faster and faster. Her eyes swept constantly across the stars, as if trying to find some “reference” that could help her fix her bearings. Duncan was just about to forcefully “wake her up” when she suddenly stopped. She jolted as if snapping out of a heavy dream and turned blankly toward Duncan: “…Report, navigation system failure.”

She went still, and seemed a bit more clear-headed than before. She patted her head, then scratched her hair in confusion: “Ah… Captain, my head just suddenly filled up with all kinds of strange things…”

Duncan grabbed Alice’s arm. Thin threads of flame flowed over his fingertips as he lowered his voice and asked gently: “What did you see?”

“Stars… lines between the stars, and numbers and symbols,” Alice answered, still with a hint of daze in her eyes, as if part of her mind was still busy with something else. “I was supposed to find a path and avoid those collapsing gravity traps… but the coordinates are off. We… we don’t have a safe route…”

Confused, she lifted her head and looked around at the Starry Sky. Those motionless stars seemed to record a distant journey. Long ago, in some universe that had already died, there had once been such a scene. She had once passed through here, guiding the last refugees as they searched for a path of escape… But escape… escape from what?

A spreading glow of dark red appeared in her mind.

The whole universe was red-shifting… the stars were coming apart, physical space was collapsing… the structure of matter was falling to pieces… the servo systems were howling at the edge of failure…

The ship was about to break apart. The navigation cabin had already caught fire… Activate Disaster Backup Protocol.

Alice's eyes flew open. The chaotic noise in her head was wiped away in an instant by some powerful force. She shook her head. Her neck joint creaked slightly—and she forgot all the messy things that had filled her mind.

A warm flame burned quietly at her side. The power in the fire slowly steadied her thoughts. She turned her head and saw the captain standing beside her, watching her with concern: "Alice, don't start overthinking yet."

Alice thought for a moment, then shook her head in confusion: "Captain, I feel like I just saw something… but I forgot!"

"I know, but it's all right. Forgetting is fine," Duncan said softly as he patted Alice's arm. "We're about to go find the answers."

"…Oh." Alice nodded, half understanding and half not.

Duncan said nothing more. While he carefully maintained the flame to protect Alice's mind, he fixed his heavy gaze on the depths of this star river.

A chain of information rose in his thoughts and slowly linked together—

Here was a frozen “holographic snapshot” of the stars. Through the long ages of the past, it had floated in the dome layer above the Abyssal Deep, above the Deep Sea, providing navigation for all the world’s mariners.

The master of the Abyssal Deep Sea, the Abyssal Lord, was called Navigator One, code LH-01.

When Alice stepped through the “black door,” she had briefly heard a voice that called her LH-03, Navigator Three.

The God of Wisdom, Rahm, had a true name: LH-02, Navigator Two. The image of that god in the scriptures always made Duncan think of a huge server, its surface flickering with countless lights.

Ten thousand years ago, a starship called the New Hope had crashed into this “ruined world.” It had tried to flee the Doomsday of its home universe, but in the final stage of its voyage, it had still broken apart and split into three pieces…

Three pieces, just enough to match three modular “hosts”…

Duncan let out a slow breath. He forced the storm of thoughts in his mind to calm down and glanced from the corner of his eye at the doll walking obediently beside him.

Now… he finally knew what the Abyssal Lord’s replicant had stuffed into this doll’s body back then, in the Deep Sea near Frostholm.

The starlight ahead gradually thinned to nothing. Beyond the dome layer lay countless shattered floating islands drifting in a dark, chaotic space.

The Abyssal Deep—the Deep Sea.

A black skeletal limb, covered in countless vicious barbs, dropped from the sky and nailed a writhing lump of flesh to the stone ground. The deformed mass swelled and squirmed as it ran, but now it was pinned in place.

That Abyssal demon, called a fear demon, let out a series of sharp, hideous shrieks. No matter how it struggled, it could not pull itself off the skeletal spike. In almost the blink of an eye, it shriveled like a punctured balloon. Thick, murky smoke rose from its surface, while what remained melted into sticky “sludge” and was quickly absorbed by the black limb.

The towering skeletal limb bent upward. At the center of twelve symmetrical limbs, a massive Abyssal demon that still kept a partly human, female shape slowly lifted her head.

Shirley calmly swept her gaze over the many broken remains on this barren land—the torn bodies of Abyssal Hounds, the death-omen birds still twitching and flapping on the ground, the Smokewisp Jellyfish and fear demon that were slowly turning into sludge, and that black skull floating crookedly in the sky, the red glow in its eye sockets flickering faintly.

Farther away, more Abyssal demons were gathering, lingering in hesitation.

Abyssal demons had no hearts. But even a demon without a heart still had some instinct to seek advantage and avoid harm—at the very least, none of them had come here just to be eaten by a stronger demon.

Shirley moved her twelve long limbs, as if she were walking across the ground on bent bone wings. She slowly headed toward the far end of the barren plain. From time to time, a badly wounded demon failed to get out of the way and was skewered by one of her long “legs,” turning into sludge that was drawn up and absorbed as nourishment.

At first, she had felt nothing but disgust about this. She had tried to step only on the clean ground, doing her best to avoid “eating” that revolting mud.

But now she no longer cared that much.

“Shirley… relax…”

She only muttered softly as she walked through the ranks of mangled demons, moving toward a direction she felt was right.

The battered black skull darted sideways in near terror, getting out of the path of this strange intruder.

But Shirley did not spare that skull even a single second of attention.

She just kept murmuring as she walked on: “…Don’t be afraid.”

On the plain, the demons drew back in fear and opened a path.

Chapter 722: The Second Beating

The huge demon with twelve symmetrical limbs and a human face finally walked away. Under the high, distant Starry Sky and the dome, her back slowly twisted and melted into the chaos far away. In the place she had occupied, there were only piles of pitch-black bones and flesh that were slowly breaking apart and drifting upward, and dozens of badly wounded “native creatures” who were struggling to recover their strength.

Several Abyssal Hounds struggled up from the heaps of bones, the plates of bone on their bodies already broken and incomplete. Death-Omen Birds circled above those lifeless remains, searching for anything useful that could help them regain their strength. The huge spiked skull slowly dropped onto the ground not far away, its dark red, hollow eye sockets staring at the demons on the plain.

After the higher-ranking demon left, a fragile and dangerous balance formed among the remaining Abyssal demons here, but this brief balance was about to be broken.

As their shared fear faded, the instincts for fighting and destroying rose again. Among the Abyssal Deep of the Deep Sea, mutual killing and devouring was the eternal rule, especially when “food” was everywhere and every demon needed to heal as fast as possible.

The Abyssal Hounds that were digging through the bones for usable plates were the first to let out hostile growls at the Death-Omen Birds circling in the sky. Right after that, Smokewisp Jellyfish floated up from the shadows, their curved, wicked tentacles quietly stretching toward the nearby Fear

Demons. The black skull also slowly lifted off the ground, its jaw opening bit by bit while dangerous energy stirred inside…

Even though a moment ago they had all been pinned to the ground and ground down by that powerful, strange “outsider demon”, it still could not stop these Abyssal demons from once again falling into mutual slaughter.

But just as the melee was about to begin, an extra sound suddenly came from not far away and at once stopped the demons in their tracks.

The pitch-black skull sensed the intruder’s presence first. It shot upward and turned its head toward the direction of the sound.

A huge shadow was staggering across the plain. It seemed to have popped out of the air out of nowhere, its swelling, writhing darkness outlining a shape that kept changing.

The scene looked like those “newborn demons” that had just emerged from the limbs of a Abyssal Deep lord. They often appeared in this formless, chaotic way. Only after a time of devouring and merging would this formless “demon mass” collapse and condense into a specific kind of demon.

However, this uninvited guest on the wasteland was clearly not a “newborn demon”. For a shapeless demon mass, the aura it gave off was far too dangerous… and strange.

Their sense of danger made all the Abyssal demons present instantly drop the urge to fight each other. By instinct, they focused their guard on that constantly swelling, writhing shadow.

Inside that mass of shadow, a solid shape slowly appeared. It was… a Abyssal Hound built from countless floating broken bones, its body almost twice the size of its kind.

Dog felt that it had had a very, very long dream.

It could no longer remember what had happened in the dream, but it remembered that it had gone to a very, very faraway place. There it had met some people, some friends. It had lived among a group of weak yet orderly beings and had spent a long time learning a set of “rules for survival”.

And a similarly weak… creature had always stayed by its side.

…Right. Where had that little weak creature gone?

Dog slowly raised its head. Its foggy vision seemed to be covered by a heavy Veil. Everything it saw looked twisted and layered. This place… looked a bit familiar, but Dog felt it had not been back here for a very long time.

Dog felt that it did not like this place—it liked much more the place where it had lived with that “little creature”, a place lit by sunlight.

In the hazy mist and the Veil, many vague shapes gathered around. Low roars and whispers came from all directions, distant and blurred. They sounded like threats, like malice.

Dog tried hard to open its eyes wide to see what those shadows that were growling at it really looked like, but it still could not see clearly. Little by little, though, it felt something else.

That feeling came from itself—hunger.

Dog was hungry, very, very hungry, as if it had not eaten for a century and had suddenly come to a place… rich with food.

Driven by that hunger, its muddled mind finally began to recall some impressions related to that long “dream”.

It remembered that little weak creature. Dog remembered that it had kept that little one company through many long winter nights. When the weather

was very cold, they wrapped themselves in blankets and hid in the house together…

They shared the hot soup from a kind neighbor. Dog only drank one mouthful each time…

They learned together how to survive in that huge city-state, how to understand the kindness and malice in people's hearts, and how to tell which things in the trash cans were useful and which were dangerous…

Begging, tricks, factories, chimneys, stealing, getting beaten, charity soup, working hard, eating their fill, crying together, laughing together, together…

…living.

In the layered blur of the Veil, those snarls full of threat and hostility rose and fell, growing more and more restless. Then a swift shadow suddenly rushed over from some direction and launched a fierce attack at Dog.

Dog felt something bite into its body—it hurt a little.

Inside the swelling, writhing shadows, Dog's skull lowered its gaze. Deep in its hollow eye sockets, a faint green light flickered on and off as it looked, with a hint of curiosity, at the thing biting into its body.

A Abyssal Hound—it looked like one of its own kind.

Dog's body quickly took shape in the shadows and black mist. Strange bone pieces stretched out from its joints, helping it regain the proper form of a Abyssal Hound. It looked at that "same kind" that was tearing at its body and, after a few seconds, finally spoke in a somewhat rusty voice: "Have you seen a human? She is my friend."

The Abyssal Hound that was tearing at Dog's body suddenly stopped in hesitation. It was not because it had understood Dog's question—it did not

yet have that kind of mind.

It had only sensed a huge danger. Deep inside Dog’s eye sockets, where a dim green light burned, there hid a very familiar, terrifying aura.

This Abyssal Hound finally reacted, but it was already too late. It had only just opened its jaws when, in the next second, all the bones on Dog’s body suddenly shattered and changed shape. Countless black bones exploded outward, wrapping around the attacker like a whirlwind, and in the blink of an eye regrouped outside the other’s body into Dog’s form again.

Using the mouth to eat was inefficient. Swallowing the whole thing at once was much more efficient.

The reckless attacker vanished. Only Dog’s tall figure remained in place. The black bones at Dog’s torso squeezed and writhed fiercely. From inside came the grinding and crunching of bones, along with the violent struggle and low, muffled snarls of the “food”. But after only a few seconds, the struggle and snarls slowly faded, leaving only the noise of bones grinding against each other.

The hunger eased.

Dog raised its head, sensing its strength slowly returning.

“Demons… taste good…”

The feast had begun.

Amid the roars and rambling cries of countless demons, Dog’s figure suddenly turned into countless black bone fragments that burst apart and flew in all directions. They swept over the whole wasteland like a broken storm. The bones cut through everything within reach—whether the living demons, the dust rising from demon remains on the ground, the mud flowing over the earth, or even the rocks on the surface and those thorny

thickets that looked like fossils. All of them were torn apart by this storm and turned into “food”.

Those Abyssal demons that refused to be devoured launched a futile counterattack. Their fierce resistance only helped fill Dog’s belly. Some demons that were better at telling danger from gain ran madly toward the end of the wasteland to escape that feeding storm. After paying the price of wounds and even losing parts of their bodies, only a dozen or so demons, badly hurt, fled to a place that was somewhat safer.

The storm lasted for who knew how long before it finally faded over the wasteland. From the storm, a huge figure then took shape, its whole body burning with dim green flame and trailing black smoke.

The hunger had gone. Dog raised its head and looked toward some place deeper in the wasteland. It faintly felt a familiar presence in the distance.

That seemed to be the “little creature” that had lived with it for a very long time.

After a few seconds of slow and muddled thought, Dog slowly turned its gaze and found a rather large demon remnant on the messy wasteland. It lowered its head, picked up that remnant in its mouth, and let out a vague murmur from its throat: “Shirley… I found food…”

It took big steps and ran toward the depths of the wasteland.

Among the wreckage and remains, the few surviving demons got up, trembling, and stared blankly into the distance.

They had survived two feasts—by luck, they had not become food, or at least had not been eaten clean.

And that trace of dim green light that had appeared in the feast was still deeply burned into the dull, confused minds of these demons.

That was fear, a kind of fear that was unconditionally stamped into the deepest logic of almost all Abyssal demons, strong enough to press down even on their chaotic instincts.

The huge skull demon, covered in spikes and black from top to bottom, floated in the air, wobbling. A full third of its body had been “gnawed” away by that storm just now, but it had still stubbornly survived. This monster, which seemed to be a bit “smarter” than normal demons, swayed a few times in the air, let out a vague mutter, and then slowly flew off into the distance.

But it suddenly stopped again.

This skull demon seemed to sense something. It jerked its head up and looked toward the dome of the Abyssal Deep above, where the frozen Starry Sky spread.

A streak of dim green fire like a shooting star was falling from the sky, dropping straight toward this wasteland!

Maybe the repeated shocks had simply been too much. At the instant that “shooting star” appeared, a hazy, chaotic “thought” actually rose in the dull, simple mind of the skull demon—

Ah, the third beating is here…

Chapter 723: Under the Dim Starry Sky

A streak of dim green flame fell like a meteor from that frozen dome of the Starry Sky, tracing a bright line before crashing down onto the barren plain full of strange rocks.

Then the flame burst apart and blossomed in midair. In the falling sparks, Duncan and Alice stepped out of it and finally set foot in this unknown world.

Before the light faded, Duncan noticed those twisted, terrifying shapes in the distance. More than a dozen Abyssal demons were gathered around the edge of the landing point, looking strangely dazed for some reason.

He and those demons stared at each other. For a moment, the air felt oddly frozen.

Only when the slow-to-react Alice finally yelled out did that frozen air break: “Captain! We’re surrounded!”

“…I see that.” Duncan answered lightly, and at the same time he was already ready to “deal with” those demons.

The dozen or so monsters in the distance were clearly different from the Abyssal demons he had seen in the Mortal Realm, the ones summoned by Annihilators. Their limbs were far more twisted. Some bodies even showed strange dislocations and cracks. The skull demon floating in midair had a horrifying hole at the top of its head. It did not look easy to handle at all.

In Duncan’s understanding, with twisted things like Abyssal demons, the more twisted and wrong they looked, the stronger they were. The demons in front of him were twisted almost to the point of breaking. They had to be top fighters in the Abyssal Deep Sea, very different from those small fry in the Mortal Realm who ran as soon as they saw him…

But what he did not expect was this: just as he finished getting ready to “say hello” to the local natives with his fists, that group of monsters in the distance suddenly seemed to come to their senses. They burst out in a mess of roars and hoarse cries, then scattered in all directions. In the blink of an eye, half of them were already gone.

The other half were not staying because they did not want to run, but because they simply could not. They were limping and stumbling. That skull demon that looked so terrifying could fly, but when it flew it was like an old diesel engine with a broken cylinder. It wobbled as it floated a little way, black smoke puffing from the big hole in its head with every two sways, then it fell to the ground. After a few struggles it floated up again, puffed out two more bursts of black smoke, and fell down again…

Even with an optimistic guess, it could fly at most six meters in half a minute. Most of the time it just sat there puffing smoke.

Duncan and Alice: “…?”

After the two of them stood there stunned for a while, Duncan finally noticed the messy marks on the ground around the landing point. Many remains that were almost beyond recognition lay scattered among pits and gullies, pouring out thick smoke as they sank into the ground. Deep craters and gouges marked the earth everywhere, as if some crushing force had scraped off a whole layer of the land. It was a terrifying sight.

At first, Duncan had thought these marks were just “natural scenery” in the Abyssal Deep Sea. After all, he had been told from the start that this place

was a “broken wasteland”. But now he finally realized… this was a battlefield left after a fierce fight.

Something had arrived here ahead of them and had almost killed all the Abyssal demons in the center of the wasteland. The dozen or so demons in the distance were just a group of lucky survivors—

So it turned out their twisted shapes had really been twisted by someone.

Alice also came back to her senses at this time. She stared around with wide eyes and noticed the black bones scattered in a nearby hollow. At once she grabbed Duncan’s arm: “Captain! This place is covered in demon remains!”

Duncan glanced at the wobbling skull demon that was trying its best to fly in the distance, and at a few Death-Omen Birds hopping on one leg on the ground. He spoke with some thought: “…So the fight already happened…”

“Who did all this?” Alice looked quite uneasy. The scene around them made her nervous. “Are the Abyssal demons’ usual fights this intense?”

For a moment Duncan did not answer. He only bent down to examine a piece of bone that had been burned almost to charcoal, then opened his hand above that fragment.

A tiny spark of dim green flame, almost invisible to the naked eye, drifted out from the charred bone and floated down into his palm.

That weak spark still carried the “memories” left on this battlefield not long ago.

“It was Shirley and Dog.” After a moment, Duncan looked up toward the far end of the vast wasteland. “They both came here before us… In theory, these marks were left by them.”

Alice listened, her face going blank for a second as she failed to process it: “…Shirley and Dog are that strong?”

“It seems something has happened to them, some great… change.” Duncan frowned, his face turning serious. “Especially Shirley. The feeling she gives me now is not quite right.”

As he spoke, he turned his gaze, following the direction in his senses where the aura of the Marks on Shirley and Dog came from.

Boundless chaos filled this endless dimension. The frozen ancient Starry Sky hung high above, covering the dome of the Abyssal Deep Sea. The dim starlight shone on broken floating islands in this chaotic space. Within his sight, he could see many large and small shadows drifting in the dull starlight. All of them were pieces of land floating in midair, and the “wasteland” where he and Alice were standing now also seemed to be only one part of those many broken islands.

The whole Abyssal Deep Sea, was formed from these countless broken floating islands. They drifted in a chaotic space covered by the frozen ancient Starry Sky, and the whole space was filled with a bleak, deathly air.

Duncan withdrew his gaze and looked at the doll at his side: “Do you feel anything special right now? Can you see or hear any unusual information?”

Alice listened carefully inside herself, then shook her head: “Nothing for now.”

“Mm.” Duncan nodded lightly, then raised his hand and pointed into the distance: “The Marks on Shirley and Dog are in that direction and still moving. We’ll go after them.”

“Okay!” Alice nodded at once. As she followed Duncan’s steps, she muttered under her breath: “Shirley must be terrified… She’s actually very timid… Dog isn’t very brave either…”

Those two figures, who gave off a terrifying aura, finally walked off into the distance—they did not seem to have any wish to cause trouble here.

The skull demon floating crookedly in midair trembled a little, the red light in its eye sockets flickering. It watched the two uninvited guests leave, and for the first time, the idea of “relief” appeared in its dull, simple mind.

A Death-Omen Bird with only one leg and half a wing hopped through the nearby rubble. Two almost flattened Fear Demons crawled slowly through cracks in the ground. A few Abyssal Hounds, nearly torn into quarters, were struggling to drag themselves farther away.

What a wonderful day.

A long limb covered in bone spurs stabbed down from the sky like a sword, pinning a strange demon that had just opened its mouth to roar and gather its breath to the ground. Then this limb stepped forward again, striding toward the end of the wilds.

On the twelve symmetrical limbs, countless strange and fearsome demon creatures of all sizes were skewered. Some of these twisted, ugly things were still struggling and roaring, but most no longer moved. They gave off thick smoke and slowly turned into mud.

But the master of those limbs no longer cared about them. After trekking for who knew how long, she finally reached the end of this piece of land.

The land floating in the chaotic darkness was an isolated island, and beyond its edge there was only endless nothingness. At the rim of this wild plain, rock and soil simply stopped. A faint mist drifted from the broken edge of the land, circling the island like a low, flowing layer of clouds.

Shirley carefully stopped at the end of the land. She used her barbed limbs to hook into cracks in the rock and cautiously leaned forward at the edge of the floating island to glance down, then quickly pulled back her gaze.

There was no road ahead.

What should she do next?

She thought about it, standing still at the end of the plain like a statue, for a time as if dead.

But the demons that circled and hesitated around her knew that this strong and terrifying “outsider” was still alive—for in her ribcage made of bones, two dark red hearts and a small flame still beat slowly, unending.

After who knew how long, Shirley finally woke from her thoughts. She controlled her limbs and stepped back two paces, trying to lower her height—she was tired and wanted to sit down and rest for a few minutes.

After a few tries, she finally sat down in a clumsy and slow way and carefully folded the bone structures on her back, which were like huge wings of bone.

She sat on a large rock like that and lifted her head, staring blankly at the frozen, ancient Starry Sky above.

That Starry Sky was very cold, wrapped in a dead and desolate air. It was like a huge, grand but lifeless corpse, looking down on all things with billions of cold eyes.

It was truly beautiful, but also truly frightening. She felt as if she were about to fall into that crowded field of stars and become their avatar, a part of them. At the same time she felt as if they were pressing down on her, pinning her to this broken and barren land.

What words should she use to describe such a sight and such a feeling?

Shirley thought hard and seriously. She suddenly felt a bit sorry that she had not listened to the captain before and read more books. Then she would have known many words, instead of thinking for so long and only managing to squeeze out one sentence—

“…It’s so damn pretty…”

Then footsteps suddenly sounded nearby, cutting off Shirley’s sigh and finally making the demons that had been hiding in the dark, ready to move yet still timid and afraid, retreat at last.

Shirley slowly turned her head and saw a Abyssal Hound taller than all the others, its whole body made of broken bones floating in black smoke, walking out of the shadows.

It came closer with care, dim green fire burning in its hollow eye sockets. It seemed to be hesitating. It looked nervous and unsure. It paced back and forth more than ten meters away for a long time before slowly stepping nearer and putting down the lump it was holding in its mouth.

“…Shirley, I found food…”

That line sounded very familiar.

Chapter 724: Reforging

The strangely familiar words threw Shirley into a brief daze. Her memories rose and fell like waves in a faded sea. From the dim, unreal foam, some old warmth and color slowly surfaced. Only after a long time did she sluggishly come back to herself and look at the massive Abyssal Hound not far away, an Anomaly in size.

It was still there waiting, filled with hesitation and nerves, and a bit of confusion.

As if sticky mud covered its mind, Dog felt many wrong places inside its head. Its past memories were blurry. Its thoughts now broke off again and again. It was not sure what had gone wrong. It only felt that… something seemed to be missing from its heart.

A faint light flickered in its hollow eye sockets as Dog stared at the nearby Abyssal demon with the strange bony limbs, a figure that looked oddly familiar. The world around it swam.

It had never met her, yet it knew her – it had known her a very, very long time ago.

[The tiny kid in my memories… why did she become like this?]

After hesitating for who knew how long, Dog finally walked forward, carefully and slowly. It sniffed around first, then stepped past those long, barbed limbs and came to stand before Shirley.

Shirley silently fixed her gaze on the tall Abyssal Hound. After a few minutes she slowly stood up and put her hand on Dog's head: "Why did you become weird too?"

Dog tilted its head in a dull way. It seemed to want to say something, but before it could speak, it felt a push at the back of its neck – Shirley suddenly reached out, wrapped her arms around Dog's neck, and pulled it hard into her arms.

"…I thought I wouldn't be able to find you…" she muttered in a low voice. Her late-coming fear made her voice tremble a little. "You suddenly fell down. I couldn't hold on to you at all…"

Dog's head felt even heavier. Its sluggish thoughts broke apart over and over and almost could not form a clear line. But at that moment, Dog suddenly heard a sound.

Thump, thump – that was a familiar heartbeat.

Dog was pressed against Shirley's chest. Through the grim, crisscrossed bones, the sound of two hearts beating slowly seemed to smash through the haze in its head. It woke up as if from a long muddy dream. With every beat, its memories rushed back. The light in its sockets grew brighter. At last it broke the silence and spoke, struggling a little: "Shirley, I… back then…"

But Shirley did not loosen her arms. Still hugging Dog's neck, she said softly: "I know, Dog… I already know."

The fire in Dog's eye sockets flickered once. It stopped struggling and asked in a hesitant tone: "When… when did you find out?"

"When I first learned that Abyssal demons don't have hearts," Shirley answered quietly.

Dog fell silent. It stayed there with its neck trapped in her arms, not moving, lost in thought. Only after a long time did it mumble: “I’m sorry…”

“It’s fine,” Shirley answered almost at once. Then she let go of Dog’s neck a little and looked very seriously at the Abyssal Hound that had stayed with her for twelve years and had almost raised her, nodding slowly as if to make the point clear. “It’s fine – you were always with me.”

Dog nodded in a slow, clumsy way. While a little comfort rose in its heart, a faint haze also suddenly returned to its mind.

That sluggish feeling, the broken memories, came back again in waves.

“Shirley, my head feels all foggy…” it blurted out.

“It might be because of this.” Shirley reacted at once, then lowered her head to look at her own chest. Two hearts were beating inside her ribcage. But soon she frowned. “…But I don’t think I can take them out anymore…”

As she spoke, she reached up and tapped the crossed bone plates on her chest, as if trying to open that sturdy “bone cage” again.

“Don’t touch them,” Dog said at once, stopping her. “You’ll die!”

Shirley froze and stared at Dog, lost: “Then… what are we supposed to do?”

Dog did not answer. Its gaze fell on Shirley’s right hand. The broken chain hung there. At the end of the chain, a faint ghostly green flame still burned.

Shirley followed its gaze. Her eyes landed on the same spot, and they had the same thought.

“…Fix this?” she asked, hesitating. “Would that work?”

“In theory I think it would. We’ve always relied on the symbiotic pact to keep us in balance, but…” Dog muttered, not very sure. “This has never happened before. It’s unheard of for someone with a broken Pact chain to live this long. And to repair the chain after that… even more impossible. To be honest, I don’t know how to do it.”

Shirley listened with a serious, thoughtful look. Then she picked up the broken piece of chain, found the other end near Dog’s neck, and held the two breaks together, fiddling for half a minute. She looked up: “…Putting them together like this doesn’t work.”

“Of course it doesn’t – even a normal chain needs a blacksmith to mend it!” Dog shook its head right away, then dropped down because of the dizziness swaying in its mind. “This thing might need a strict ‘recasting’ process… The important part isn’t the chain itself. It’s the symbiotic pact between us…”

Shirley listened hard and tried to think, but she still could not help grumbling: “In the end… how did the chain suddenly snap in the first place? I only remember you suddenly saying you felt unwell in that cavern, and then you sank into the ground…”

“I’m sure it’s tied to the Abyssal Lord, and it’s also tied to those ‘truths’ you suddenly ‘saw’ on that plaza before,” Dog said. It fought the haze in its head while forcing itself to analyze. “There were prophetic omens before the chain broke. The first changes happened right after you ‘saw’ the memories of Holy Land Island…”

It suddenly stopped halfway through, as if it had caught some possibility. A moment later it went on: “…Those cultists were twisted by corruption the instant they learned the ‘truth’. They turned back from humans into ‘Rough Husks’. You were under the Captain’s protection, so it looked like you

weren’t affected by the corruption at the time – but what if the corruption still worked anyway?”

Shirley froze and lowered her head to look at her current body.

Dog kept thinking aloud beside her: “You formed a symbiotic pact with me, a Abyssal demon, from the very start. That was long before you met the Captain. So the ‘corruption’ had already taken root in your nature. The memories of Holy Land Island woke it up. They awakened your Abyssal demon side. Because that power was already inside you, it partly slipped past the Captain’s protection…

“The chain between humans and Abyssal demons is, in truth, a ‘symbiotic pact contract’ between two living beings. This kind of contract has strict conditions to exist. In other words, when your nature changed, it broke the conditions for the contract…

“It’s like a business contract. If one side loses the ability to fulfill it because of some force they can’t resist, the contract naturally fails…”

Shirley listened, stunned and dazed. After a long moment she finally asked: “So… what then?”

Dog thought it over: “If we can’t fix it, we make a new one. Maybe we can build a new symbiotic pact contract – not based on how you used to be, but on how you are now.”

This time Shirley understood.

Hope lit up again in her chest, and her energy came back at once: “Then what should we do? How is a symbiotic pact contract normally made?”

She and Dog had been “in a symbiotic pact” for more than ten years, but from the start it had never been a normal contract. She had never held a summoning ritual like the usual Annihilators, so she knew almost nothing about this.

But Dog clearly knew a lot more than she did.

“For Annihilators, the hardest part of a ‘symbiotic pact contract’ is the preparation. They usually have to reshape themselves with a whole series of ritual acts, including all kinds of bloody ‘surgeries’ and mental remolding. This is mixed with many dark and evil dealings, all so their life form becomes closer to the ‘primordial’ state. Only then can they withstand the power of Abyssal demons. But for you, that’s actually the least important part.

“You can skip it completely. You’re already closer to that so-called ‘primordial’ state than any Annihilator, and you’ve long adapted to the power of demons.

“So all you need to do is carry out a simple summoning ritual – that’s actually the easiest part.”

As Dog spoke, it staggered to its feet and began walking slowly across the rubble-strewn wasteland. With its claws it carved deep grooves into the ground. It was drawing a complex set of runes, writing the “text” of the contract.

“Form a link… summon a demon… That part is simple for us. I can prepare all the runes and the site for the ritual. I’ll also provide the power needed to start the array. All you have to do is stand on the node at the edge of the ritual field. When I’m ready, you picture the demon you want to summon in your mind.”

It looked up and met Shirley’s eyes as she watched with curiosity. Dog continued very seriously:

“Normally this summoning can take a full day or even longer. It opens a rift, and you wait until a demon willing to answer appears at the center of the rune matrix. Then the contract is formed. But…”

As it spoke, Dog slowly walked toward the center of the runes. Around it, more and more symbols began to light up.

“But Shirley, you don’t need to wait that long – I’m already here.”

Chapter 725: Knowledge Changed Fate

All the runes were ready. The “text” of the symbiotic pact contract was written on the ground of the Abyssal Deep, in the soil of the Deep Sea. The summoner stood in place. The demon had also taken the proper position. All the conditions to start the ritual were now complete.

Dog stood in the center of the rune matrix. Its eyes, lit by dim green flame, fixed their gaze on Shirley at the edge of the array. As its mind grew more and more muddled, it slowly nodded.

With Dog’s encouragement, Shirley walked to the node of the array and tried to calm her thoughts.

She knew nothing about these complex runes. She had never received any formal occult studies training. She knew even less about the deep, dark rituals of Annihilators. Now she was full of unease. Faced with these mysterious symbols, she felt nothing but nerves.

But she trusted Dog – she needed this friend. She had to reforge their bond.

She took a light breath and slowly closed her eyes, using all her memories and imagination to sketch the demon she wanted to “summon”.

That figure had already long been carved deep into her mind over many years. She did not even need to draw it carefully in her heart. The familiar shape rose up in her thoughts at once.

The runes on the ground began to glow slowly. The Ancient Communication Protocol of the Deep Sea era woke with its own strange logic and shape. A hidden, subtle sense of connection appeared at the same time in both Shirley's and Dog's awareness. As the rune matrix brightened, that link grew steadier…

Yet only a few seconds later, all the runes went dark with no warning at all. The link that had just formed snapped in an instant. A short, piercing screech split the air, making all of Dog's charred bone plates rattle and the twelve bony limbs behind Shirley shiver.

Shirley jerked out of her trance, eyes wide with shock as she saw all the runes die at once. Her body swayed. At the same time she saw Dog in the center of the array snap its head up.

The ritual to reforge the symbiotic pact contract had failed.

"How could this happen…" Confusion filled Shirley's face. She glanced at the runes she did not understand at all, then looked up at Dog, who looked just as lost. "Did I mess something up? Or did you get the runes wrong?"

"That shouldn't be… I felt it start up…" Dog was clearly puzzled too. It stepped away from the spot that stood for "demon" and came to Shirley's side to examine the area around the node. "These runes are definitely right. This knowledge is almost burned straight into my mind. You should have done fine too, or they wouldn't have lit up… I don't know where it went wrong… The whole process just jammed halfway…"

Shirley frowned hard. She noticed the fire in Dog's eye sockets had begun to dim, and its speech was breaking. She grew flustered at once: "I… let's try again!"

Dog nodded at once: "Yes, try again!"

They returned to their positions and ran through the process once more – but the result was the same.

The rune array flickered into life for a moment, but only held for a few seconds. Then, like a broken machine, it “jammed” and shut down completely with a short shriek.

Shirley started to panic. In that brief link just now, she had felt Dog’s state growing worse and worse. Reason and humanity were fading from it. In its waves of confusion, it could hardly even recognize her shape.

As the dizziness grew stronger and its thoughts cut out more often, Dog staggered over to the node where Shirley stood. It could barely support its body, so it forced itself to lie down. It tried to focus and spoke in a low voice: “No… I must still be missing something… The ritual layout is… is fine. The problem should be… in our current special states. We have to… make an adjustment…”

“Adjust? Adjust how?” Shirley asked quickly. “Should I stand somewhere else? Is the node in the wrong place? Or is this area not suitable…”

But Dog seemed no longer able to hear her. Its head drooped. Disturbing clicking came from inside its body. Its skull swayed from side to side, and only a string of low murmurs came out, words that Shirley could not understand at all.

Just then, Shirley suddenly sensed a familiar presence. A deep, stern voice followed, one that in this moment made her feel both safe and overjoyed: “What are you doing?”

Shirley and the groggy Dog lifted their heads almost at the same time and looked toward the voice.

Duncan and Alice stood not far away in the wasteland.

“Captain!?” After a short pause and blank stare, Shirley reacted with a jolt. She seemed to forget how her body had changed. When she stepped forward, she almost tripped over herself. But she quickly caught her balance with her long bony limbs behind her and rushed to Duncan. “Captain, you have to help Dog. It… it’s in terrible shape. Our link is broken, and the reforging ritual just now also failed, and I don’t know…”

“Stop, stop, slow down,” Duncan quickly raised a hand to cut off Shirley’s fast babbling. He frowned a little as he looked at the girl before him, who had changed into a completely different form. He could still confirm by her mark that this was the Shirley he knew, but her current demon posture shocked him. Dog in the distance also looked very different. “What exactly happened to you two?”

Shirley froze, her lips trembling a little: “I… our chain broke.”

Dog seemed to recover a bit just then. It struggled to raise its head: “We… tried to hold the symbiotic pact contract ritual again, but the ritual failed…”

“The ritual failed?” Duncan frowned at once. As he walked toward the rough, makeshift array on the ground, he asked: “What exactly happened?”

“It started up and then suddenly stopped,” Shirley said. She braced herself with her limbs as she followed Duncan and quickly explained what had happened, repeating the “knowledge” Dog had just shared with her. “…I stood here, and Dog stood in the position for the ‘demon’, but it didn’t work…”

As she spoke, she stepped past the Dog that still could not move and hurried into the center of the array. She pointed at the ground while explaining to Duncan: “This was where Dog stood just now. The runes all lit up around here, just… like they’re… now…?”

She trailed off.

She had seen the runes around her suddenly give off a faint glow. Next, every rune in the array began to light up one by one and flash in a complex pattern.

Duncan, who had only just worked out how this so-called “contract ritual” flowed, also saw this. His expression slowly grew a bit odd: “…?”

Shirley and Dog shared the same reaction: “…?”

The ancient communication protocol had taken effect.

Alice saw special “lines” stretch out at the same time from both Shirley and Dog. In the blink of an eye, those lines met in the air, guided together by the dim light of the array. They merged and quickly underwent a transformation into solid matter, reforging the broken chain.

The process happened so fast there was no time to react. By the time Shirley truly realized what was going on, the chain between her and Dog was already whole again.

Then the Pact Array finished its duty. All the runes completely darkened and slowly took on a dry, ashen look of exhaustion.

Shirley stood in the center of the array, stunned for a moment. At last she stepped away from the “demon” position. She lifted her arm. The black symbiotic pact chain clattered and rattled. At the other end of the chain, Dog, now recovered, slowly pushed itself up from the ground and shook its huge skull.

The fire that had almost gone out in its eye sockets burned bright once more. It shone again with the wisdom of someone who had reached the absolute peak of high school graduation, half a step into City-State University.

The air grew a little awkward for half a minute.

“So, if I understand this right,” Duncan said at last. He stood beside the ruins of the array, looking at the two “crew members” before him, whose chain had been rebuilt while their forms stayed the same. “Dog, you really are Shirley’s ‘guardian dog’ now. And Shirley… you’re now Dog’s ‘contract human’.”

Shirley stared blankly. Dog also froze in place.

Alice had been spacing out at the side this whole time. Now she finally reacted and suddenly asked: “Why did it turn out like this…”

Shirley kept staring.

But Dog’s wisdom suddenly got moving again. It thought for a moment and then spoke, hesitant: “…Purity.”

Duncan’s look turned strange: “Purity?”

Dog lifted its head and pointed at Shirley, who now had some human features but, overall, looked almost like a full Abyssal demon: “Her purity as a Abyssal demon… is very high.”

“…That’s not right,” Shirley finally snapped out of her daze. After hearing Dog, she spoke at once. “No matter how pure I am, I can’t be purer than you. I just have the demon part of me showing on the outside. You’re from ‘over there’ from the start…”

Listening to their wild yet very serious analysis, Duncan looked at Shirley, then at Dog. He also felt this whole thing was rather unbelievable, so he couldn’t help thinking it over. Then a strange idea popped into his mind, one he could not quite push away: “Maybe…”

Shirley and Dog spoke together: “Maybe?”

“Maybe it has to do with Dog being ‘marked’ by the god of wisdom Rahm,” Duncan said. He thought a bit, and though he knew the idea sounded

ridiculous, he still looked very serious. “It didn’t get dragged away back then, but now it really is the god of wisdom’s Saint – that is probably the reason.”

Shirley’s expression went blank again: “…”

After a short pause, Duncan stepped forward and patted Shirley’s arm (she was so tall now that he could no longer reach her head). He spoke in a heavy, heartfelt tone: “This is why I always say that knowledge changes fate.”

Chapter 726: Shirley & Dog

On the shattered floating island under the frozen starlight, Dog and Shirley walked to the edge of the land and sat down, staring into space.

A pitch-black chain extended from Shirley's arm, which was covered in black bone plates, and linked to the back of Dog's neck. Their two minds flowed quietly along the connection formed by the chain, blending together, sharing reason and humanity—just as they had for the past twelve years.

They had a lot they wanted to talk about. In that short yet terrifying time after the chain broke, this pair of "partners" who had relied on each other for twelve years had faced things they had never imagined. Even Shirley, who hated thinking the most, now found herself reflecting on life.

Of course, they also had to think seriously about how to adapt to this new relationship—"guardian dog" and "contracted human", a setup that would blow everyone's mind if the world ever heard about it…

Duncan did not disturb them. Instead, he took Alice a little farther from the edge of the floating island and, while he waited, looked around to study the strange environment of the Abyssal Deep.

It was very quiet all around. On the wasteland under the dim starry sky, he saw no sign of life.

Many Abyssal demons had gathered here before, but to avoid another beating they had all fled long ago. Now only a barren plain full of strange black rocks remained, along with some jagged, rising and falling shadows in the distance.

If he had not known he was in the Abyssal Deep, Duncan would have thought the scene before him belonged on a barren alien world. The land around him looked like the surface of a dead planet, and the frozen starry sky above gave off a bleak, heavy feeling. It was not a pleasant environment at all.

And if he remembered that the only “animals” here were countless savage demons, and that their daily life was to gnaw on each other, gnaw on rocks, and be gnawed on by their own kind, then this place was even farther from anything that could be called “livable”.

“…I’m starting to think the Four Gods Church’s plan isn’t reliable,” Duncan said casually. “I mean the plan about settling in the Abyssal Deep. In a hellhole like this, even if humans really managed to survive, they’d be twisted beyond recognition. A ‘civilization’ that is no longer human at all—can that still be called human civilization? I really doubt it.”

Alice thought for a moment, half understanding, half not.

But she did not seem bothered by the environment at all. She even adapted to it very well. She was still wandering around in high spirits. The bare plain and the dim light did nothing to affect this doll’s good mood. She ran over to pick up a strangely shaped rock and happily held it out to Duncan: “Captain! Look, look, a rock!”

Duncan pulled his thoughts back at once and looked at the rock Alice had picked up with a serious, grave expression: “What is special about this rock?”

“From the side, doesn’t it look a lot like Goathead?” The doll girl burst into a smile, her face full of pride. “I saw it at a glance!”

Duncan: “…”

While he was still stunned, Alice ran off again. She dug around among the jagged rocks nearby, brought back a handful of things, and showed them to Duncan in delight: “And these! Don’t they look like tree branches?”

Duncan looked at the twigs in Alice’s hands. They had seen a lot of these along the way. They looked like thin branches of some kind of shrub, growing from cracks in the rocks. Their surface carried grayish-white lines, yet they only had bare stems and no leaves at all. Their shape was very strange.

At first glance, anyone would instinctively think they were a kind of plant unique to the Abyssal Deep.

But Alice casually snapped one of the twigs and pointed at the broken end: “Look, this thing is stone too.”

Duncan frowned slightly and took the broken twig from Alice, curiously examining the cross section. The thing seemed very brittle. The break was neat and sharp and had the same texture as the black and gray stones on the ground around them. But when Duncan held it up under the starlight and looked more closely, he saw tiny glimmers faintly reflecting from the break, as if fine metallic dust or fibers were mixed inside it.

Then he raised his head and looked toward the wide space in the distance under the dim starry sky. Large and small broken islands floated in this dimension. Some were almost as big as the greatest city-states on the Boundless Sea, while others were only large rocks. But no matter how big an “island” was, they all had one thing in common in their structure:

The lower half of every floating island was a regular “disk”. At the bottom of each disk he could see many clustered downward-pointing shapes like stone stalagmites turned upside down. Massive structures of unclear shape linked those hanging spires together, as if forming the “base” that supported each floating island.

Duncan frowned a little. He could not help but think of the “mirror world island” he had seen once on the seabed near Frostholm. That black mirror world island, which floated in the Abyssal Deep, also looked as barren and raw as these broken floating islands. The whole island had been covered with the same kind of “black stone” material, with that faint metallic feel.

Clearly, they were made of the same kind of thing.

If those Black Mud Homunculi shaped like humans were the “Rough Husks” of people, then that barren, dark mirror world on the seabed near Frostholm had been the “Rough Husk” of a city-state. And here in the Abyssal Deep… it seemed to be packed full of “Rough Husks” of city-states.

Maybe these were the raw “blanks” the Abyssal Lord had used during the third Long Night. Or, to put it another way… were they the “half-finished products” of the many islands on the Boundless Sea?

If all of these were half-finished… then it was clear that when the Abyssal Lord had first built the Sanctuary World, He had planned something far grander: more islands, more city-states, wider living spaces, richer resources. It was even possible that, in the original plan, the Boundless Sea was meant to be many times larger than the world people knew today.

But now these “half-finished products” only floated quietly in this cage-like space, letting the years pass, forgotten by both the mortal world and the gods. Only the dull, chaotic Abyssal demons fought here day after day, keeping up a meaningless cycle and “balance” of matter.

Suddenly, footsteps came from the side and pulled Duncan out of his thoughts.

He looked up toward the sound and saw two tall figures walking over. One was Shirley, still in her Abyssal demon form. The other was Dog, whose

mind had completely recovered.

“Looks like you’re done talking.” Duncan took the initiative to walk forward, breaking the silence first.

“Thank you for giving us time,” Dog lowered his head and said politely. “I hope we didn’t delay anything.”

“We still have a lot to do—but we’re not in such a hurry that we can’t spare ten minutes,” Duncan said casually, while he watched Shirley’s and Dog’s faces. (He mainly watched Shirley’s, since it was hard to read any expression on Dog’s bony skull.) “You both seem to be in good shape. Have you talked about what to do from now on? I mean your new contract relationship… this unheard-of case where a demon summoned a contracted human.”

Even as he said it, Duncan himself felt that the words sounded strange. But Shirley and Dog seemed very calm when they heard him. Dog even shook his head carelessly: “That’s not a big deal. Shirley and I both feel it doesn’t change much for us…”

Alice’s eyes went wide in surprise: “No change at all?”

“Yeah,” Dog said, utterly at ease. “Shirley has always been the one charging around with her head down, and I’ve always been the one holding the chain so she doesn’t cause trouble. How did the captain put it… oh, ‘the dog walking the person’. We’ve lived like that for more than ten years. Isn’t it still the same now?”

Duncan and Alice looked at each other. After a few seconds, they spoke in unison: “That… does make sense…”

Listening at the side, Shirley drooped her head so low it almost fell into her chest. She muttered in embarrassment: “Can we not talk about this… I’m not that reckless…”

Duncan felt that this young lady's words had no force at all. From the day she first swung Dog on his chain and threw him out to beat people, she had never again been able to clear her name of being "reckless"…

But after this little interruption, he did feel a bit more at ease. It really seemed that Shirley and Dog did not care much about this "small matter" of the contract changing, and that spared him a lot of needless worry.

Shirley lowered her head and glanced at Dog, who was linked to her. She gently shook her arm, making the chain clatter.

The chain still bound them together, just like always. Whether one was human and the other a demon, whether one shared whose humanity, whose heart beat in whose chest… none of that was very important.

They were "Shirley and Dog"—and they always would be. As long as they stayed together, that was enough.

"Then there's only one other question left." After a few seconds of quiet, Duncan cleared his throat and broke the silence. He looked up at Shirley, who now "stood grown up", almost three meters tall when her skeletal limbs held her up. "In this form… can you still change back?"

"I can," Shirley nodded right away, but then her expression turned a little hesitant. "After the chain was restored, Dog and I 'noticed' a way to take control of my body again, it's just…"

Duncan looked puzzled: "Just what?"

"There's a tiny bit of side effect…" Dog muttered at the side.

As soon as he finished speaking, Shirley began to control her new body and transform it back toward a human form—

With a series of cracking sounds as bones reshaped and clouds of smoke rising, her huge body shrank quickly within the haze. In just a few seconds,

she returned to a normal human height and size. The frightening black bone plates and spikes all withdrew into her body. Her once-mature face also went back to how she usually looked, except for…

Her eyes, which still glowed with a faint red light.

She looked up at Duncan with those eyes now completely covered by red light and spoke in a helpless tone: “This is a Abyssal demon trait. I can’t get rid of it. Dog can go back to how he looked before—his whole body just shrinks a size. But my eyes won’t change back no matter what I do. One look and you can tell something’s wrong.”

“…Honestly, it’s pretty striking,” Duncan commented in a very objective tone.

Shirley held it in for a long moment, then let out a long sigh: “Whatever… I’ll just keep my eyes closed whenever I go into a city. I can see things even with my eyes closed now anyway.”

Chapter 727: Uncertain, Discontinuous

Amid another series of bone-shifting cracks and rising black smoke, twelve symmetrical black limbs once more stretched and grew out. Dark bone armor slowly covered her body, and bone spikes sharp as blades flashed with a bloody chill. Shirley had changed back into her Abyssal demon form again.

She was adapting at an amazing speed to controlling her two forms. Her control over this body grew more and more natural. The whole process felt less like learning from scratch and more like knowledge that had long soaked into her mind and limbs, and now she was simply “remembering” it bit by bit.

She moved the limbs behind her that helped her walk and flexed her hands and feet. Shirley nodded in satisfaction: “In a place like this, I feel a bit safer like this.”

Dog raised his head and looked at Shirley, who now towered far above him. Then his body was suddenly wrapped in a swirl of smoke. He seemed to melt, shrinking and merging into the shadows beside Shirley.

Duncan watched quietly from the side. When Shirley’s form finally settled, he stepped forward and said: “I thought you would reject your demon body. A transformation this drastic is… pretty shocking to an ordinary person’s worldview.”

“We’re already in the Abyssal Deep, and you still care whether I look good or not?” Shirley poked at a stone on the ground with one of the limbs behind her, looking completely unconcerned. “I’m a… what was that word again? Oh right, a ‘pragmatist’. First I make sure I can stay alive safely, then I think about whether I’m living well. To me, there’s nothing wrong with this demon body. It hits hard and can take a hit. It’s very useful in the Abyssal Deep. If it has any flaw, it’s that it keeps sucking in dead demons’ remains on its own. Ugh… just thinking about it is a little gross…”

As soon as she stopped talking, a dog’s head poked out of the shadows at her feet: “…Actually, I think they taste pretty good. Shirley, are you sure you don’t want to try that bone I brought you?”

Shirley answered without hesitation: “No. It’s nasty!”

Duncan watched them quietly, and at last a faint smile appeared on his face.

“Then the only thing left for us to do is find that ‘Abyssal Lord’,” he said, steering the topic back to the main point. “There are countless floating islands here. This whole space is far larger than I expected. Dog, can you tell where we are exactly?”

The dog’s head poked out of the shadows again. Dog looked around very carefully, then gave the captain a small nod: “This should be the upper layer of the desolate ring belt—the area closest to the starry sky. If I’m right, we need to go ‘down’.”

Duncan looked curious: “Down?”

Dog nodded. After exchanging a few words with Shirley, he walked to the edge of the broken wasteland and leaned out, looking down into the boundless chaotic darkness below.

Below the floating island, in the long stretch of void, the chaotic, dim starlight grew even weaker. Duncan could just make out more floating

islands drifting there in confusion. But at the very bottom of all that darkness, he also saw something else… tiny points of light, faintly flickering.

At first, Duncan thought it was another “starry sky” hanging upside down at the bottom of the Abyssal Deep. But he soon realized that those faint points of light were actually lamps, slightly shining on the surface of some structure so huge it was hard to believe.

Those faint lights, almost swallowed by the dark, spread out in the distance. Together they roughly outlined winding, curving branches and a “trunk” in the center of all the branches. The lights on that main trunk were denser, and they moved slowly along it, like something alive.

Standing at the edge of the broken ground, Duncan used his gaze to quietly watch that dim, crowded field of lights. He could not tell how far it was from here to down there, nor how large the “body” behind those lights really was. But even from such a rough look, he could imagine what a giant thing it had to be.

“That’s the Abyssal Lord—the ‘mother body’ of all demons and the place where demons go after they die,” Dog said from the shadows, his voice carrying a faint, strange emotion. “At the very bottom beneath all the broken islands, His limbs stretch to the ends of the Abyssal Deep. The visible part of His body alone is equal to dozens or even hundreds of city-states. As for the parts you can’t see—the ends of His feelers—those pierce through the ‘bottom’ of the Abyssal Deep and reach into Subspace. They can’t be measured or judged with any language that follows normal math.”

“Every minute and every second, countless demon ‘substrates’ grow in that dark abyss. They are like wisps of smoke, drifting up from the ‘bottom’ on irregular, invisible winds. Through a series of broken spaces, they are sent to the floating islands above. There they devour each other and, in that

process, become all kinds of solid beings. Then they fight and kill each other without end. The demons that die turn back into smoke and sludge and, after a short or very long wandering, return to the abyss below to be absorbed by the Holy Lord. It goes on and on, a cycle without end."

"I have broken free from this cycle… but for the Abyssal Deep as a whole, that change is tiny. The demons' cycle of devouring will not stop, and the 'operation' of the Holy Lord will never end."

Duncan listened quietly to Dog's story without saying a word. Only when Dog finished did he give a small nod: "So we just have to go down there?"

"That's the problem. 'Going down' is not easy here," Dog said, lifting his head out of the shadows to look Duncan in the eye. "Do you remember a very strange and troublesome 'trait' of the Abyssal Deep?"

"…You mean that space isn't continuous here?" Duncan thought for a moment. "I remember we talked about this. In the Abyssal Deep, moving from one place to another is very uncertain. Direction and distance are completely random. But on our way here, we never felt that problem."

"That's because we were on an island. Within a single floating island, space still follows the continuous structure we know. But if you leave these islands…"

As Dog spoke, he stepped out of the shadows. He picked up a small stone nearby, took it in his mouth, and flung it far out into the wide darkness beyond the edge of the floating island.

The stone vanished from everyone's sight in the blink of an eye. As soon as it passed two or three meters beyond the island, it simply disappeared into thin air.

Alice stared wide-eyed at the direction the stone had flown. After several seconds she could not help asking: "Where did the stone go?"

“No idea. There’s only a very small chance it ‘fell downward’,” Dog said, shaking his head. “Up, down, left, right, front, back—any direction, any distance, any landing point is possible. It might be falling from the starry sky right now. It might already have hit some unlucky demon on the head. Or, of course, it might have landed straight on the Abyssal Lord. When a solid object moves in the ‘void’ between floating islands, everything is completely random.”

Duncan frowned: “…So the cycles you just talked about—the demons cycling between the islands and the Holy Lord—are random like this too?”

“Yes,” Dog nodded. “Everything is built on uncertainty. A demon born from the Holy Lord might need hundreds of years before it gains a body on some floating island. A demon corpse killed by its own kind and thrown into the void might ‘fall’ in the dark for a thousand years before it reaches the deepest part of the Abyssal Deep. And that ‘fall’ could be in any direction…”

As he spoke, he lifted his head and looked at the dim starry sky above.

“Given how huge the Abyssal Deep is and how endless the number of demons are, we can even guess that some of the very first demon substrates that split off from the Holy Lord are still drifting in the dark, never having gained a solid body. And among the demons who died in those earliest battles, there may be some still ‘falling’ through that darkness after ten thousand years, never yet reaching the bottom. All of that is entirely possible.”

Uncertainty. Broken space. A “chaotic cycle” system built on countless random events…

How bizarre it all was.

Duncan furrowed his brow, sketching in his mind a world "order" that completely went against common sense based on Dog's words. After a moment of thought, he said: "…But the Vanished once fell straight through the Abyssal Deep."

"Yes. And that's what made it most terrifying," Dog said. The ghostly green flames in his eye sockets shrank slightly. "In fact, compared to 'being crushed to death by a ball of fire falling from the sky', the idea that 'something can fall from above and is certain to hit the bottom' shook the demons of the Abyssal Deep even more. Demons have no real minds, but at least they can live in this chaotic place by instinct. The Vanished's appearance completely broke the 'rules' here. That kind of thing—impossible to understand, unreasonable, breaking the laws of this place—is what drove many demons mad on the spot."

Dog paused, his tone turning very serious: "Do you understand what I mean now? For the Abyssal Deep, the idea that 'something can fall from above to below, and that this falling always works'—something that is taken for granted in the Mortal Realm—is 'unspeakable' here. The Vanished's fall did more than smash a few islands and kill tens of thousands of demons. It 'pierced through' the very order of the Abyssal Deep itself."

Duncan thought for a moment: "…So you're saying that, for the demons' mental and physical health, I'd better not cause any more 'falls' here?"

"Not for the demons' health—their way of living isn't very healthy anyway," Dog shook his head. "It's for the 'health' of the Abyssal Deep itself. This place is already unstable. If you smash it one more time, it might really spring a leak."

Duncan rubbed his chin and stayed silent for a moment.

As he struggled to think about how to solve the problem of discontinuous space outside the floating islands, and how to reach the "bottom" where the

Abyssal Lord lay, he suddenly felt someone tugging at his sleeve.

He turned his head and saw Alice’s big, pretty eyes.

The doll raised her hand and held something dark out to him: “Captain! A rock!”

Duncan froze, his expression turning a bit odd: “Uh, Alice, now isn’t the time…”

He suddenly stopped talking.

The rock in Alice’s hand… was the same one Dog had thrown out just now!

Chapter 728: Navigation

Duncan was very confident in his memory. He happened to remember exactly what the stone Dog had just thrown looked like, and now he was sure the stone in Alice's hand was that very same one.

Dog quickly realized something was wrong too. It stared in shock at the stone in the doll's hand and said: "…What are the odds? It fell right into your hand?!"

"No," Alice shook her head at once, looking as if this were only natural, "I picked it up and brought it back."

"You… picked it up?" Shirley's face instantly looked like she had just seen a ghost. She stared straight at the doll and asked: "How did you pick it up? According to what Dog just said, shouldn't this thing have ended up in some random place in the Abyssal Deep?"

Alice fell into thought at once, as if she was trying to figure out how to explain a process she herself could not really put into words. She waved her hands while she spoke: "Just now, when we were talking about where things that fall from here might end up, I got curious about where that stone went. Then I found it. Then I just picked it up… that's all…"

As Alice spoke, she casually made a motion of plucking something out of the air, as if this were completely normal. But her explanation did not just confuse Shirley; even Dog felt lost listening to it.

Duncan, standing to the side, suddenly frowned. Something came to him in a flash.

When they crossed that frozen, ancient starry sky, Alice's strange behavior… LH-03, the Navigation Mainframe.

His expression changed slightly. He bent down at once to pick up another small stone from nearby. After letting Alice see it clearly, he threw it hard out into the boundless darkness beyond the floating island.

Just like before, once the stone flew a few meters beyond the island's edge, it vanished from everyone's sight in an instant.

Duncan turned back and looked into Alice's eyes: "Do you know where it went? Can you pick it up again?"

He had barely finished speaking when Alice already raised her hand and held out a small, pitch-black stone, her face bright with the look of someone asking for praise: "Here, the stone!"

Even though he already had a guess in his heart, Duncan still could not help going blank for a few seconds when he saw the doll bring the stone out again so simply and casually. No one had seen how Alice "picked" it back up. Even he had not seen it.

It was as if the whole process had been skipped. "Addressing," "route," and "arrival" had all been compressed into some unobservable crack in time, leaving only the "result" as output.

Shirley finally could not hold back her favorite filler word: "…Holy crap, this is just way too absurd…"

Dog seemed to notice something from the change in the captain's expression. It turned its skull and asked, puzzled: "Do you know how she did that?"

Duncan's face grew a bit more serious. After a brief hesitation, he nodded lightly: "…Alice has another identity. It might be called 'LH-03'."

Dog froze. This time it spoke in unison with Shirley: “…Holy crap, this is way too absurd…”

“We can talk about this later. Maybe once we meet the Abyssal Lord we can get more answers.” Duncan waved his hand and did not continue on that topic. Instead, he turned his gaze to Alice. “Do you have a way to take us to the ‘bottom’?”

Alice tilted her head. Then she held one hand to her temple and carefully walked to the broken edge of the land. She leaned out to look down at the endless darkness below and the little points of “starlight” faintly twinkling in that darkness, as if she were working hard to observe and think.

After a long time, she finally stepped back two steps and pointed into the vast darkness beyond the floating island: “Here, there are countless lines and ‘paths’. Some of them connect to ‘down below’. I think we can follow them down… but I don’t know how to take you with me.”

Just as she finished speaking, Duncan took a step forward: “Let me take a look.”

As he spoke, Duncan put his hand on Alice’s shoulder. At the same time, a flicker of phantom-like ghost?green flame rose in Alice’s eyes.

A vast, complex, almost frightening structure appeared in Duncan’s sight.

He saw the world through the doll’s eyes—at least, part of that world.

He saw endless fine strands, like drifting hairs, growing from the bottom of the Abyssal Deep and stretching upward until they connected to the frozen, ancient starry sky above. He saw countless lines crisscrossing within that starry sky. Some merged downward. Some seemed to vanish into the depths of the sky as if into thin air.

He also saw faint, tube?like structures filling the darkness beyond the floating island. They crossed, broke, and shifted without pause, like some

runaway network of “paths”. Just one glance made him dizzy. There was no pattern he could grasp, much less any way to see the whole.

Duncan frowned. He really did see that massive web of lines and paths, but all he could do was “see” it. He could not spot any pattern in it, and there was no way he could find the starting point and end point of any single path in such a short time. To him, this tangle in the Abyssal Deep was like some “encrypted data block”, pure gibberish.

Yet through the link created by the flame, he could dimly sense Alice’s state in that moment—she did not feel there was anything chaotic about the massive information in her vision at all.

Everything in her eyes was neat and ordered. The jumbled paths in that starry sky and the network of lines in the dark could have driven all the scholars in the world mad, but for her… it seemed that in any given instant, she could calculate the start and end of any single path.

In fact, right then and there, she was still calculating without pause. A huge computation, one she herself could not sense, was booming away in the depths of her mind every second without stopping.

Duncan blinked. Against the background of the countless lines that filled the whole Abyssal Deep, he seemed to see Alice suddenly turn her head. She smiled softly. Her lips did not move, yet a voice went straight into his ears:

“Welcome to the navigation database of the New Hope. It stores billions of gravitational signatures and calibration parameters between the stars, and can simulate in real time the relative motions of any celestial bodies in deep space, in order to calibrate the Star Map… We will cro&?ss the stars, and at the e&?nd of light?speed reach our new home ()*&*??%… We will sur%#vive, and rebu*&ild the old)*world… ~*&”

Like a kind female system voice, the broadcast gradually picked up static. Delay and distortion blurred the tone more and more, and then, in an unnoticeable instant, it cut off.

Alice was still carefully studying the dark space beyond the floating island. She clearly had not turned around, and she had not spoken.

Duncan raised his hand and dispelled the ghost?green flame linking him to Alice.

The dizzying lines and tube?like paths vanished from his sight at once.

Alice turned around and smiled happily: “You saw it all, right, Captain? I wasn’t wrong, was I?”

“I saw it. But I’m afraid only you can handle the ‘navigation’ from here.” Duncan took a light breath and looked seriously at the doll. “You take us down.”

Alice froze for a moment, then hurried to speak: “But I don’t know how to bring other people…”

“It’s all right. I know. We’ll follow you. You only need to trust your own judgment and walk forward without hesitation. Can you do that?”

Faced with the captain’s unusually serious expression, Alice could not help feeling a little nervous. But at last she still nodded, and her face became serious too: “Mm, I can!”

Duncan nodded slightly, then stepped back half a step and spread his arms.

A column of ghost?green flame shot up into the air, spiraled upward, then began to spread out around him as its center. After that, it flowed toward Shirley, Dog, and Alice.

He recalled his experience when he had once “fused” with AI, then reminded them softly in his heart: “Shirley, relax a little. Don’t be afraid.”

“I… I’m not afraid!” Shirley’s voice came at once from beside him. “Dog is the one who’s scared!”

All the bones in Dog’s body shook as if someone had turned on a vibration setting. It trembled while still trying to sound tough: “D?d?don’t talk nonsense. I?I’m relaxed. The captain, he… he knows!”

Duncan shook his head with a smile. In the rising flames, he turned his gaze to the doll in front of him: “Alice, let’s go.”

Alice nodded, then turned around without hesitation and walked toward the boundless void beyond the floating island.

A mass of roaring ghost?green flame disappeared into the darkness that rushed up to meet it.

At the same time, deep within the Sacred Isle in the Mortal Realm, Lucretia and Morris, who were keeping wary watch over that black door, both heard a strange, low rumble.

The sound seemed to come from deep behind the door. It pierced the surface of the “door panels”, which rose and fell slowly like liquid mercury yet were as black as mud, and echoed again and again through the cave.

In that brief daze, Morris felt as if he heard a string of blurry words. He could only make out a few of them: “LH-03… reconnect…”

“Did you hear someone talking?” The old scholar snapped out of his trance at once and turned his head toward the “Sea Witch” beside him.

“No,” Lucretia answered at once, while staring hard at the surface of the black door that was constantly rippling and writhing. “But I feel like… something is about to come out of there.”

Almost at the same moment, Morris also felt those auras full of malice and madness. Some chaotic, frenzied presence seemed to have finally

discovered this crack leading to the Mortal Realm and had started to gather toward it.

Morris had to push down his questions for now. Right after that, he saw something take shape in the writhing darkness of the door—a twisted, grotesque Abyssal demon that struggled and squeezed its way out of the gate and stepped into the Mortal Realm.

Lucretia instantly raised the Conductor’s Baton in her hand and turned it into a black scythe gleaming with cold light. Morris, however, suddenly froze when he saw the demon’s form.

It was the first time he had seen a demon invading the Mortal Realm look like this.

After a moment of stunned silence, he and Lucretia looked at each other.

“…Why does this Death?Omen Bird only have one leg?”

“No idea… kill it first, talk later.”

“Fair enough.”

Chapter 729: Contact the Elder Gods

A sharp streak of blade light flashed past. A lump of flesh that kept swelling and shrinking, a “fear demon” that whispered and murmured in eerie tones, was cut clean in half, then quickly turned into rising smoke and slowly twitching scraps.

But more ominous auras were still gathering in the cave. Whispers and overlapping howls that could corrupt the mind of any ordinary person continued to pour from deep within that black door.

More and more Abyssal demons had sensed this crack leading to the Mortal Realm. They were invading through the gate one after another. Their invasion was triggering chain reactions across the entire Sacred Isle and had begun to change the “environment” of the island.

Lucretia flicked the black residue from her scythe and lifted her head, staring with a grim face at the black gate that kept heaving and writhing. She said in a low voice: “…I feel like the ‘atmosphere’ on the island is changing.”

“Vanna just sent word. Abyssal demons are appearing in the valley,” Morris said quickly. He was holding a complex brass device in his hands, its surface carved with layers of intricate sacred sigils. While he spoke, he kept a wary eye on the movements within the black door. “They’re showing up in the mist. Some have already begun to take on solid bodies.”

Lucretia frowned: “We clearly took care of all the demons that came out of the door… Could there be some other ‘entrance’ on the island?”

“It’s the ‘breath’ of the Abyssal Deep,” Morris shook his head. “This island sits on the border. It was never a stable part of the Mortal Realm to begin with. Now this black door is slowly dragging the entire Sacred Isle over to the other side. The aura leaking out of the gate is changing the ‘depth’ of this whole region… The deeper it gets, the more easily Abyssal demons grow out of thin air.”

Lucretia’s face was dark as water. She glanced at the pile of ghost?green flames still quietly burning before the black door, then calmly lifted the scythe in her hand: “It’s not a big problem. There’s still a fleet outside and a whole crowd of professional Church warriors. These demons won’t be hard to deal with. You just keep watch here. I’ll handle whatever comes out of the door. Father should be back soon.”

Morris neither agreed nor disagreed. Out of the corner of his eye, he saw new outlines slowly forming on the surface of the rippling black door.

More demons were entering the Mortal Realm. At first, a few odd, misshapen creatures—missing limbs, twisted bodies—came stumbling out of the gate. They were easy to deal with. But after that, all that squeezed through were “fully formed” Abyssal demons, the type Morris knew well.

They were savage, powerful, and filled with uncontrollable rage. Any one of them breaking into a city?state would mean a horrible slaughter.

Worse still, these chaotic, dull?witted demons were almost immune to all spell effects based on “wisdom” and “knowledge”.

But that was not a big problem either.

Morris pressed the “mechanical device” in his hand against his own shoulder. The delicate mechanism, which seemed to be made of brass, sank

into his body like a phantom in an instant. Right after that, the sounds of gears turning, pistons moving, and valves venting gas came from inside him.

With a soft benediction to Rahm, the God of Wisdom, the old scholar's bent, aged body seemed to be filled for a short time with the strength of steel and oil. His back slowly straightened, and his spine gave off clacking sounds like metal parts snapping into place. A metallic sheen spread over his skin, shining with the unique luster of brass. His eyeballs melted away. Two carefully cut rubies rolled out of his Sorting Engine brain and were pushed into his eye sockets by mechanical arms.

Morris flexed his arms. Steam hissed from his joints, and thin white mist puffed out. He lifted his head toward the shape squeezing through the black door—a huge, floating skull covered in savage bone spurs—and strode forward.

He passed Lucretia and drove his fist into the horrifying skull demon. With a shriek from the venting steam valves and a crisp crack of shattering bone, that demon, which had been in the Mortal Realm for less than half a second, was punched straight back into the Abyssal Deep by the old gentleman.

Lucretia lifted her head and stared blankly at the usually gentle and mild old scholar: "…?"

"When I was young, I often went seeking knowledge in dangerous secret realms and even into Vision zones," Morris turned his head, the brass shell of his face showing a faint smile. Fine brass gears and shining springs spun and trembled in the gaps along his jaw. "Out in those places, far from the civilized world, you often ran into crude enemies who lacked the brains they needed. Back then, I learned a truth—fools are immune to the baptism of wisdom."

He turned around and slammed another punch onto the head of a Abyssal Hound that was just sticking out of the door, smashing the demon’s skull straight down into its chest.

“The knowledge of Rahm’s divine blessing can’t leave even the tiniest mark on their smooth brains.” Morris shook his wrist, letting the steam?pressure tubes in his joints reset. “But a Steam?Powered Iron Fist blessed by Rahm can.”

Lucretia kept the same blank look: “…”

And to think she had once believed this gentle, good?tempered old mister was the most normal person on the Vanished… so in the end, there was not a single normal person on Dad’s ship?!

…

When the Abyssal demon that had suddenly emerged from the thick mist was flattened in the blink of an eye, Amber still had not reacted to what had happened.

She did not even know how Vanna had rushed from one end of the valley to the other in a single instant.

After swatting a demon to death, Vanna walked over as if nothing had happened. She was holding the greatsword in one hand as she stopped in front of Amber: “The demons are gaining physical bodies. This ‘Sacred Isle’ has already sunk deeper toward the Abyssal Deep. Inform the warships near the shoreline that they must stay alert for large entities appearing in the nearby waters. No matter what they look like, if they dare come close, sink them.”

Amber froze for a moment before she finally snapped out of her brief daze and nodded in a panic: “O?okay!”

Seeing this, Vanna frowned. Years of serving as an inquisitor made her scold without thinking: “Focus, nun. We’re on the demons’ turf.”

“Yes!” Amber straightened her back on reflex and answered loudly.

Vanna waved her hand and did not say anything more. She simply looked around with a grave face, watching the thick mist that was slowly flowing through the valley.

Ever since half an hour ago, strange and shifting shadows had begun to appear from time to time within the fog. Those shadows swam and twisted, sketching out many disturbing demon shapes.

On the nearby rock walls, clusters of stone as grim as exposed bones were also giving off faint tremors, as if they were slowly becoming active.

And just a few seconds ago, demons had condensed into solid bodies out of the shadows in the mist, “born” directly into the Mortal Realm.

All these signs showed that this “Sacred Isle” was rapidly drifting away from the Mortal Realm and “sinking” toward the side of the Abyssal Deep. This change was clearly related to the captain’s actions.

Vanna did not feel uneasy. She trusted the captain. But the others on site clearly did not know enough about the Vanished fleet.

“Is everything okay over on the Vanished?” Amber leaned closer and asked in a worried whisper.

Vanna frowned, looking puzzled: “…What are you talking about?”

“I know that ship is strange and powerful, but Captain Duncan is away right now, isn’t he?” Amber hurried to explain. “If demons really come close… should we ask the Tide to help watch over it?”

Vanna understood Amber’s concern, but her expression only grew more complicated. After a brief silence, she shook her head: “It’s fine. There’s

someone staying on that ship.”

Amber stared, as if she still wanted to say something. But just then, a sudden burst of intense light rising from the direction of the shoreline cut her off.

The marines and priests stationed in the valley all jumped and turned toward the source of the light. For a second, they even thought they were seeing a blazing sunrise.

A glaring fireball was slowly rising into the sky. In the scorching, terrifying light, it looked as if many tiny things were burning in the flames, turning into thin threads of smoke.

After staring in a daze for a long moment, Amber finally broke the silence in a hesitant voice: “…What is that?”

“That’s ‘Nina Gets Spooked’.” Vanna pressed her lips together, narrowed her eyes at the fireball, and spoke in a very calm tone. “She jumped really high this time… Looks like the Abyssal demons that showed up in the nearby waters are ‘in luck’ today…”

…

In the sudden assault of darkness and chaos, Duncan, Shirley, and Dog felt as if they were traveling through an endlessly long tunnel. Only an instant seemed to pass, yet their senses told them this “journey” went on without end.

At the far end of that “tunnel”, when the darkness began to fade, countless bizarre visions rushed toward them. Twisted starlight poured into their eyes like a waterfall. Shirley and Dog were stunned at once by the scene, both grand and eerie. Duncan, however, suddenly had a strange association.

The jump had ended.

The moment that thought appeared, he once again felt solid ground under his feet. The long tunnel and the flashing starlight vanished from his sight. In their place came the gloom at the deepest point of the Abyssal Deep, and the massive, mountain?like, awe?inspiring “Elder God” that slowly came into view as his vision cleared.

He had arrived before the Abyssal Lord.

He could see only a small part of this Elder God.

A low “mountain range” stretched across his field of view. In truth, that “mountain range” was a single immense, dark?colored tentacle. Dim blue light flowed over its surface, and many irregular points of light were set between those streams, brightening and dimming slowly like a breathing pattern.

This giant tentacle stretched off into the depths of the darkness. There, it split into many branches that connected to several shattered floating islands hanging nearby, wrapping around and piercing deep into those drifting lands. At the other end of the tentacle stood a structure like an immense, towering pillar. It was the point where many similar tentacles met. The whole thing looked like some strangely shaped “starfish”. At its center, the “main body” rose high, covered with countless points of light, like millions of eyes slowly blinking in the dark, gazing down at the uninvited guests who had come here.

Duncan lifted his head and quietly looked up at the Elder God lurking in the darkness. After a long time, he spoke softly: “I came to find you.”

Ripples spread over the surface of that dark “mountain”, and a low murmur answered him. Within that murmur, Duncan heard a voice:

“We finally meet, ‘Flame Usurper’… and you as well, LH?03. It has been a long time.”

Chapter 730: LH-01’s Memory

Under the distant, dim starlight, the Elder God towered like a star-shaped mountain range, sending out deep, rolling tremors. Its voice was enough to drive even the firmest-willed humans mad, enough to make the rules and order of the Mortal Realm collapse—yet when that voice reached Duncan’s ears, all he felt was… weakness and exhaustion.

That was ten thousand years of time wearing things away, and the heavy burden of an entire world.

Before coming here, Duncan had prepared many questions to ask. But after hearing the voice from that dark mountain, he still chose to ask about Alice first: “So that ‘tentacle’ in the Deep Sea beneath Frostholm really was something you released on purpose? LH-03… Navigator Three. What exactly was going on? Why did you send Navigator Three into the Mortal Realm in the form of ‘Alice’?”

The star-shaped mountain stayed silent in the darkness. After a long moment, the deep tremors sounded again: “Because that was the only way to keep LH-03 running… My core program is falling into chaos. It can no longer support the sandbox environment that keeps LH-03 stable.”

At the side, Shirley and Dog held on to their sanity only under the captain’s protection. Yet when they heard the captain talking with the Abyssal Lord, they could not help doubting their own minds again: they knew every word, but they could not understand a single sentence—what was a core program? What was a sandbox?

But the captain clearly knew what he was discussing with that terrifying Elder God.

After only a few seconds of thought, Duncan linked many clues together and guessed what the Abyssal Lord—Navigator One—was talking about.

“You mean… after the New Hope broke apart, LH-03 kept running inside you?”

A reply came from the mountain: “It seems you already know a great deal.”

“…I found that key.” Duncan nodded after a slight pause.

He believed the other side would know exactly what he meant by “the key.”

As expected, the Abyssal Lord had no doubt at all. A low, gentle hum came from its body, as if it was giving approval, and then it spoke slowly: “Since you already know about the New Hope… our communication will be much easier. Yes, everything is as you said.”

Then it fell silent again. It seemed to be sorting fragments of ancient memories inside its vast database, or perhaps it was trying to choose its words, thinking how to explain things that had happened before history itself in the easiest way to understand. After a long time, Duncan finally heard the Elder God’s whisper from within that dark mountain—

“At the beginning, there were three of us.”

Dense lights flickered over the Elder God’s body, like rivers of stars it had once watched flow by.

“Our Creators were a wise and tenacious people. Before the disaster came, they slowed the flow of time, then spent an entire century building that ship inside the Time Capsule—and creating the three of us at the same time.

“I was the first to be born. My duty was to recreate everything of our civilization when the New Hope reached its new home. For this, they gave

me the mission of creation and replication, and made it so I could understand and reshape all matter.

“Navigator Two was born after me. Its duty was to control the ark’s operation, and to record and process all digitized data. After the Creators went to sleep, it would think in their place and decide the ship’s fate.

“Navigator Three was the youngest of us. Its duty was to guide the ark along the right route through the stars. For that, it recorded the positions and evolution rules of all known stars, and it controlled every engine system on the ark.”

Before Duncan’s eyes, the winding, towering mountain range slowly dimmed, then was lit again by countless lights, showing its awe-inspiring outline.

“I… want very much to describe our civilization to you here, the civilization of our Creators. I want you to know how splendid it was, bright and beautiful like a treasure among the stars. But… all of it has vanished at the end of the stars, and slow, clumsy language cannot bring back even a trace of that glory. I… can only say that, on a suitable day, we set off.

“We took everything of our civilization with us.

“Before departure, I was ordered to devour the Creators’ Homeworld and store everything on the planet’s surface in my memory banks so I could copy it later. Navigator Three chose the most likely safe point deep among the stars and ignited the engines at the very moment the Time Capsule broke. Navigator Two then took over the ship’s other systems and kept the Creators’ sleeping minds safe in the depths of its sea of thought… Then, before the Deep Crimson that marked Doomsday swallowed everything, we set sail.

“Because of gaps in the database, I can no longer tell how long we traveled. I only know that… we kept moving forward, following the route Navigator Three planned, while that Deep Crimson chased us from the far side of the universe like a tide. Stars collapsed beside us, the structure of time and space broke apart behind us, and the universe slowly fell to pieces. In the end, everything became completely different from what the database had recorded.

“In fact, at the very moment we left, Navigator Two had already calculated the end of this journey. It always could work out the final result of things in advance, and our voyage… in the end, did not escape its calculations.

“After our last hyperspace jump, we reached the end—the ‘safe’ new home Navigator Three had computed. Under the probe’s divine gaze, that world fell apart.

“The starry sky went dark all at once. Dazzling light poured from a huge rift. We fell into it. Countless broken fragments slammed into the ship’s shields and hull. A strange world crashed against the edge of our universe—this was the last information we received before Navigator Two’s signals turned chaotic. After that, our ship broke apart.

“And that break-up… completely destroyed the ark world inside the ship. The worst damage was in the navigation bay where Navigator Three was. Its physical structure was torn to pieces.”

The tremors from deep within the star-shaped mountain calmed for a while. In front of Duncan, however, a “river” suddenly rose from the ground. Its surface flickered with a dim blue light. The thick fluid flowed from the mountain’s direction as if it reflected the starry sky. It wound past Alice’s side, then slowly seeped back into the earth.

Alice stared with wide eyes, watching all of this in amazement.

“I did everything I could to save our ark, including Navigator Three,” the Elder God’s deep, layered whisper reached Duncan’s ears again. “I devoured everything around us and stored it inside the ‘Creation Vault.’ I also devoured LH-03’s wreckage and kept its data in my redundant databases… I wanted to preserve everything of the ark world, because at the moment we passed through that rift, I already saw the last instant of our home universe breaking apart.

“The Creators’ order for me was to rebuild our civilization. And we… were all that our civilization had left.”

In the darkness, the deep tremors slowly calmed. Duncan thought in silence for a long time and did not speak. Only after an unknown while did he suddenly break the quiet: “But your condition has worsened.”

“Everything is getting worse, Flame Usurper. This Doomsday has not ended. It has only been delayed—my weakening is just a tiny link in its progress,” the Abyssal Lord answered even more calmly than Duncan had expected. “But even when hope was thin, the Creators still built the New Hope. Even after Navigator Two had already calculated the journey’s result, it still authorized that expedition. The Creators told me that doing something is always better than doing nothing.

“So I released LH-03 into the Mortal Realm… Even then, I did not know if it meant anything or how things would turn out. To keep the runaway state from spreading, I cut off all connection with that part of the data carrier. Because of that…”

It paused for a moment, as if choosing its words. Then the star-like lights on its surface began to flicker again: “To be honest, when I saw LH-03’s current ‘state’… I was quite surprised as well. This was not in the plan.”

“The ‘data carrier’ you released built a shell based on a human’s form, then stuffed LH-03 inside it. She is now called Alice,” Duncan said with a soft

sigh. “To be honest, that process was pretty random.”

“…But in any case, LH-03 survived. In the end, it guided you here to me.”

Duncan frowned slightly at those words: “Was that part in your plan?”

“No. Unlike LH-02, I am not good at calculating many things. My duty is only to copy and create. But… I believe in fate. Fate can guide certain things.”

“…Hearing a machine say it believes in fate feels a bit strange,” Duncan said with an odd expression. “…Do you mind if I call you a ‘machine’?”

“I do not mind. That term feels close to me. No one has called me that for many years,” the Abyssal Lord remained calm. “So then, what else do you want to know?”

Duncan fell silent for a few seconds, then asked: “Instead of what I want to know, let us talk about your goal. You went through a lot of trouble in Alice’s manor to make contact with me and bring me down here to the depths of the Abyssal Deep. That cannot be just to chat… What do you want me to do?”

This time, the “mountain” in the darkness stayed silent even longer. The countless lights on its surface and the dark blue streams of light all went out, as if dead. Time stretched on, until Shirley and Dog even started to worry that the Lord might have been stumped to death by the captain’s question. Only then did the lights and streams flare to life again.

The Elder God’s whisper echoed through the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea—

“Flame Usurper, are you willing to take over all of this?”

Chapter 731: Before It All Began

The whole Abyssal Deep and Deep Sea seemed to fall silent at that moment. The entire dimension sank into dead stillness. Even the drifting dust between the floating islands stopped in the air. For a long time, no one spoke. Only the Elder God that looked like a mountain waited for an answer. Lights as dim as distant stars slowly flickered over its body, full of patience.

After an unknown time, Shirley's voice finally broke the stillness beside him: "…Wow…"

Duncan raised his head and calmly looked at the "mountain": "I hope you can be a bit clearer—what does 'take over all of this' mean?"

Amid soft tremors, a very human-like sigh seemed to come from deep within the star-shaped mountain. Then it spoke slowly: "Flame Usurper, you may already know that in the so-called 'third Long Night,' I did not carry out every plan on the Blueprint. The Boundless Sea is not a perfect Sanctuary World. In a sense, my 'Genesis Protocol' failed, just like the attempts of the King of the Pale giants and the King of Dreams. The only difference is… this failure was delayed by ten thousand years."

Standing in the deepest part of the Abyssal Deep and Deep Sea, hearing with his own ears an Elder God who had shaped all things admit its failure was a shocking experience even for Duncan. He had already gathered many clues about this, yet he still could not help letting out a long sigh after hearing the Abyssal Lord's words.

After a while, he finally broke the silence: “Yes, I know. Many clues point to this. I have seen those city-states called mirror world in the Deep Sea of the Mortal Realm, and those unfinished ‘half-finished products’ in the Abyssal Deep and Deep Sea. I have also learned the truth about the Abyssal demons—in a place called Sacred Isle, I saw that hall where data on tens of thousands of living creatures was recorded…”

“All signs show that the present age of the Deep Sea is actually just some half-true scraps of civilization struggling on after Doomsday. As a ‘Sanctuary World,’ it is full of flaws.”

Alice listened and muttered quietly at the side: “Isn’t that a little too blunt…”

“That is already very polite,” Shirley whispered back in a low voice.

Their quiet talk was then cut off by the tremor from the dark mountain: “Yes, it is full of flaws—and now this flawed Sanctuary World is also slowly reaching its limit… Flame Usurper, how many times has the Observer Effect stabilizing anchor failed?”

Duncan’s eyes changed at once: “…Twice already.”

“It is the key that lets the many ‘ashes’ inside the Sanctuary World stay stable, balanced, and compatible. Under its light, those conflicting, untranslatable fragments of worlds left after the Great Annihilation can collapse into a single Mortal Realm. Its failure means the flaws that existed when the Sanctuary World was first built have already piled up to the limit—once it goes completely dark, this clump of ‘ashes’ we forced together will scatter again.”

“…So what does that have to do with me taking over ‘all of this’?” Duncan spoke slowly. “The Sanctuary World is already on the verge of its limit. Do you think it will be reborn just because I take control?”

“In my calculations, yes.”

Duncan felt a jolt in his heart at that quick and firm answer from the Abyssal Lord. In that instant, he realized something—the Elder God knew him, this “Flame Usurper,” far better than he had expected!

His expression hardened at once, and he asked in a serious voice: “Why?”

“…Because you are an observer stronger and more stable than the Observer Effect anchor,” the lights on the dark mountain’s surface flowed and flickered like a river of stars. The Abyssal Lord’s voice echoed through the entire dimension: “If you take over all of this, your power will be enough to cover every flaw in the Sanctuary World. All the unbalanced systems will regain stability and return to the perfect state they had at the very beginning.”

“…You seem to understand me better than I do myself,” Duncan said after a short silence. He still did not answer the “invitation.” Instead he frowned and added: “You, and the other so-called ‘ancient Elder Kings,’ all seem to know more about me than I do.”

“…We are only guessing at your nature through long observation. Even after guessing for ten thousand years, we still have not figured out what you actually are,” the Abyssal Lord’s tone grew slow and hesitant, as if it was uneasy about something. After a brief pause, it still went on: “Flame Usurper, do you truly not know where you came from, or what your nature is?”

Duncan did not speak for a moment.

As for his own origin and nature… by now, he actually had many clues. The information that had appeared in the darkness, that “message” sent from the human civilization at the end of time to the distant past, and that 0.002-

second universe… all of them pointed to the truth of the individual called "Zhou Ming."

But after a few seconds of hesitation, he chose not to answer this Elder God he was meeting for the first time. Instead he asked in return: "I want to know what you meant by 'long observation' just now. You, and the other 'ancient Elder Kings'—when did you first discover me?"

"…We saw you in the first shock wave raised when dozens, even hundreds of worlds crashed together—you were the earliest of us, Flame Usurper."

Duncan's expression shifted slightly, but in the next instant it returned to calm.

He had been the earliest one… He had come to this world long before the age of the Deep Sea began, in a time far older than ten thousand years.

It was not in New City-State Calendar year 1900. It was not on the day the Vanished returned to the Mortal Realm. It was not when he, as "Zhou Ming," pushed open that door…

He had only woken up on that day.

Expecting something in your heart was one thing. Hearing it with your own ears and confirming it yourself was another.

Yet Duncan simply stood there calmly, as if every shift of feeling had sunk to the deepest part of his body. Then he nodded lightly: "…Go on."

"…To this day, we still do not know why that collision happened. The only thing certain is that only a very small number of… 'survivors' came out of it, and those lucky or unlucky survivors are the ones called the 'ancient Elder Kings.'

"Our survival was a result full of accidents and twists. Our nature… changed completely after that collision. At that time, time itself was in

chaos. Space was squeezed and torn. We rose from the hot, chaotic ashes left after the Great Annihilation. When we first confirmed each other's existence, it was almost another disaster—many died from corruption during that 'first contact.' The ones not strong enough, not lucky enough, soon became new ash in the ash heap. In the end, only a dozen or so figures remained. Among them… were the few names you already know.

"And you were there from the very start, sleeping deep inside a 'cocoon' we could not understand. You never woke up and did not even have a form. In our observation… you were a mass of formless light, and you seemed separate from everything around you. You did not react to the outside at all—through three Long Nights, countless gatherings, and countless changes strong enough to reshape the world, nothing affected your existence.

"In fact, if you had not suddenly begun to move in recent times, I would have thought you would sleep like that forever, always keeping that form of formless radiance, until this destroyed world was destroyed again…

"And 'our' observation of you took place under such complete silence from your side. Tarrigan was the first to grasp your name. He called you the 'Flame Usurper,' but he kept the reason for that name to himself. Navigator Two understood your power or 'property' to some extent. As for the King of the Pale giants… he stood at the center of the ashes and used his divine gaze on you for seventy-seven cycles of the clock. He left only one sentence—he said he would meet you again. After that, until he died in the first Long Night, he never spoke another word."

The Elder God's deep tremors echoed through the Abyssal Deep and Deep Sea. Ancient, dim starlight fell from the sky, carrying a strange chill.

"Flame Usurper—we still cannot understand what you truly are. But in the long years before you woke, we kept casting our divine gaze on your

sleeping ‘cocoon.’ That formless radiance showed each of us different truths and futures. And now, it is my turn to be the first to meet you.”

Duncan did not speak for a long time.

He needed to slow down—his thoughts were too tangled and had to be sorted out.

An incomprehensible “cocoon,” an invisible thing sleeping deep inside it… Was that what he had always looked like in the eyes of the “ancient Elder Kings”?!

And those “Elder Kings” who had survived the worlds colliding in the Great Annihilation had been watching him like this all along… and had even gained many “revelations” from this long observation?

A strange feeling filled his heart. After a long while, Duncan finally spoke with a frown: “What about you, then? What ‘insight’ did you gain from all those years of watching? Was it just that I should ‘take over’ this ‘Sanctuary World’ you created today?”

Under the dim starlight, the grand star-shaped mountain fell into darkness for a brief moment. Then every light on its surface came on at once, and each dark blue stream of light slowly swelled. A deep rumble rose from the mountain’s depths. In Shirley and the others’ stunned divine gaze, the central “peak” of the mountain slowly opened. A dark red core, flickering between light and shadow, rose from its deepest point like a giant single eye, calmly fixing its divine gaze on Duncan.

“No,” that dark red core spoke, its voice stiff and cold like a machine. “The revelation I received is that you will set the whole world on fire—all timelines, all flows of history, every last flame of civilization left in any world will gather into a single, unheard-of ‘Cremation Fire.’”

Chapter 732: Branch Point

Under the cold, dim ancient stars, Duncan stared quietly at Navigator One's dark red core, which looked like a giant eye. For a moment, it felt as if the whole world had stopped. In that blur of time, Duncan had a feeling: a branch point, a turning point that would decide the fate of the world's history, was coming toward him.

In that silence, he remembered something he had heard from the Gravekeeper after entering the Nameless King's tomb:

The Observer who had reached the end of the timeline had sent back the first and also the last message—time had ended, and the Flame Usurper had set the whole world on fire.

After a long time, he let out a soft breath and broke the silence. He asked: "Do you think this is a bad omen? You want me to take over this world so that future will not happen?"

But the Abyssal Lord's answer surprised him again.

"No," the dark red core trembled and spoke in a calm voice. "I do not rely on any 'revelation' or 'prophetic omen' that lacks enough data. When key information is missing, it is not careful to judge something as 'good' or 'bad' based only on broken pieces of data. I do not know whether you will truly burn this world in the end, and I do not know under what conditions you would choose to do it—there is not enough data. I cannot reach a conclusion.

“I want you to take over only because, within all the information I know now, this is the plan that has the best chance to work and is the safest way to keep the Sanctuary World going. Compared with a future I cannot understand or judge, I trust my current calculations more.”

In that answer, Duncan heard a special kind of calm reason and precision. It was what remained after stripping away the worldly title of “Abyssal Lord” and the identity of “Elder God”. It was the nature Navigator One should have had as one of the core mainframes of the New Hope.

Facing the Flame Usurper and this branch point in history, this ancient “machine” used the way of thinking it had learned at its birth to state its view and to calculate the world’s future.

Duncan thought for a long time. The dark red core seemed endlessly patient as it waited for his answer.

After a long time, Duncan broke the silence in a low voice. He asked: “If I really take over, what will happen?”

Deep inside that mountain in the darkness, rumbling and shaking rose again. With a series of low booms, its “main peak” began to sink, and the dark red core descended from the sky. Like a star falling from the heavens, it grew quickly in Duncan’s and Shirley’s sight. With a suffocating sense of pressure, it came down from the mountain top to right in front of Duncan.

At such a close distance, Duncan saw that the core was even larger than he had imagined. It was almost as large as the Storm Cathedral in Pland. The surface of the huge sphere had a crystalline texture. Deep inside the clear red shell, he could see countless fine and complex lines. Several lights flickered near the heart of the sphere, and some thick liquid flowed and coiled around them.

“After you take over, all flaws in the Sanctuary World will be fixed. Across the entire Boundless Sea, all the ‘corruptions’ and ‘distortions’ born from Cognitive Shift and the Observer Effect entering runaway state will be recalibrated by your perception. There will be no more dangerous nights, no more supernatural manifestations in runaway state devouring humans. The sea will become safe, and the city-states will enter a new age of prosperity. For a very long time that we can foresee, this peace and prosperity will keep going. If that is what you want, then it will happen.

“And you will return to being one of the ancient Elder Kings, to the place that should have been yours. You will become the fifth deity that shelters the mortal world, beyond the Four Gods. Your rule will be more stable than any of ours, because you will not slowly go mad like the other ancient Elder Kings, and you will not fall into runaway state. At least, according to Navigator Two’s calculations, your state is more stable than all of ours.

“After that, you can keep doing whatever you want—anything at all, including returning to the Mortal Realm and continuing your travels and adventures, as long as you wish.”

“…It all sounds good,” Duncan stayed quiet for a few seconds before he spoke slowly. “Is there nothing bad that will happen? For me, or for this world?”

“Within the range of information I know right now, in my view, no,” the light deep inside the dark red core flickered. The Abyssal Lord’s answer was simple and direct. “Everything will move in a good direction, and in my judgment, this should also fit your wishes.”

“…Normally, at this point you should at least mention a few minor risks or flaws. That would make what you just said sound more convincing.”

The dark red core stayed silent for two or three seconds and then said: “… Confirmed again. There are no risks or flaws.”

Duncan and the core fell silent again at the same time. Off to the side, Shirley seemed unable to hold back. Her eyes moved between the captain and the “Lord” again and again. After quite a while, she finally muttered in a small voice: “Captain, are you really going to become one of the gods? It sounds pretty amazing… but for some reason I just don’t feel… very sure about it…”

Duncan did not speak. He simply kept his gaze fixed on the huge core. After quite some time he slowly asked: “…What exactly do I need to do?”

The dark red core fell silent for a moment. The light inside it grew brighter. It said: “Ignite me.”

Duncan’s expression finally changed a little: “…Ignite you?!”

Why did this “Navigator One” say something unexpected every time?!

But the dark red core seemed not to notice the change in Duncan’s face or voice. The sound from within it stayed as calm as ever: “Ignite me, just as you ignited Frostholm. Use your flame to cover and reshape everything. In this process, all of my divine authority and all of my influence on the mortal world will be taken over by you. This may also help you put all your doubts to rest… you should know that your flame can do this.”

Duncan frowned slightly and asked: “So in fact, when I ignited Frostholm —or to be strict, when I ignited the Deep Sea under Frostholm—you ‘touched’ my flame and learned about my power, and only then did you make this ‘takeover’ plan?”

“Yes. When that split-off cluster was burned by you, it sent back a final packet of data to me. It included an analysis of your power. I compared that result with Navigator Two’s observation records from back then and made this Takeover Plan. The calculations told me it was workable.”

“The ‘split-off cluster’ you mentioned that I burned, that was the tentacle in the Deep Sea under Frostholm, right? Wasn’t that an error replicant you produced while you were in runaway state?” Duncan reacted at once, and also thought of something else you had said at the start. “Wait… you also said earlier that you sent data fragments that carried LH-03 into the Mortal Realm. You did that through that same tentacle… you were controlling all of that on purpose? You have not actually gone into runaway state?!”

He looked in confusion at the dark red core before him, and at the huge body behind it that rose like a dreadful mountain range. He suddenly realized that he did not truly understand the Abyssal Lord’s current “state”. This Elder God trapped at the bottom of the Abyssal Deep… had it really gone into runaway state?

Right then, he saw the lights on the surface of those winding “mountains” flicker and flow again. At the tip of one of the “mountains”, some new “thin branch” seemed to spread out of the main trunk’s skin and grow fast in the darkness.

But in the next second, that new branch was swallowed by some unseen force. It broke apart. Part of it rose as dark smoke, drifting up toward the countless floating islands and the dim starry sky above. The other part turned into flowing sludge and fell back onto the main tentacle.

“…Flame Usurper, this is my ‘runaway state’.”

The voice from the dark red core pulled Duncan’s attention back.

Duncan drew back his gaze and faintly understood: “…Overgrowth?”

“This is my instinct—and also the duty the Creator gave me.”

Duncan slowly caught on: “Your duty is…”

“To remake my homeland and rebuild the Homeworld I devoured,” the dark red core said slowly. “But in this narrow Sanctuary World, my mission is

doomed to fail. So, from a certain moment on, my instinct began to… drift away from the first design. Those individual bodies that split off from me again and again, devoured each other, and returned to me, those branches that overgrew and then kept withering, and that tentacle that pierced into the Mortal Realm—all of these were results of my gradual runaway state.

“However, this kind of runaway state can sometimes be used. When my main body has already lost the ability to move, those overgrown parts can sometimes act as sensors or as channels of communication. They help me learn about changes in the world and send messages out.”

“…So that is how it is.” Duncan nodded slowly and spoke in a thoughtful tone.

A huge body that had lost control, already covering the whole bottom of the Abyssal Deep yet still overgrowing. A main core trapped deep inside that vast body, unable to move. An ancient AI that could still think clearly but was doomed never to finish its first mission. This was the true form of the “Abyssal Lord”.

And now, this ancient AI, trapped inside its own vast body, sent him an invitation once more—

“Flame Usurper, what is your answer? Are you willing to take over all of this and return to the ranks of the ancient Elder Kings?”

Duncan lifted his head from his thoughts and saw the dark red core move a little closer to him again. All he had to do was raise his hand, and he could touch its unguarded crystalline surface.

“…Captain, it is telling the truth,” Alice said suddenly beside him.

Duncan looked at Alice in some surprise. The doll slowly nodded, her expression a little tangled: “I also… don’t know how to explain it to you, but I just know that everything it says is true.”

Duncan did not speak. He only listened quietly to Alice’s words. After thinking for a moment, he slowly raised his hand.

He touched the dark red core. A faint warmth came to his fingertips.

It beat softly like a heart.

“…Light the fire, Flame Usurper,” the core said, its body trembling gently. “Then I will also be freed from this long mission.”

Shirley opened her eyes wide. Dog stood still at her side and watched everything.

For one moment, it was as if they already saw ghost-green flame leap up into the air. The dark red core and the dark mountain range in the distance were set alight in an instant, and the whole Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea were swallowed by the blaze.

It was as if they already saw all the hidden dangers of the Deep Sea era smoothed away, the flaws built into the Sanctuary World at its design repaired, and the world on the Boundless Sea return to peace, lasting for a very, very long time…

A new deity would return to the place that belonged to Him, like gears locking into place and a puzzle coming together.

But all of a sudden, Duncan pulled back his arm.

“No.”

History moved onto another branch.

Chapter 733: After the Branch

With a howl that tore the air, a heavy alloy greatsword crashed down toward the ground like a falling star. The blunt-edged blade had no sharpened edge, yet it sliced a giant demon the size of a heavy tank clean in half as if it were butter. Then, with another thunderous boom, Vanna slammed her fist into the earth. In the terrible shockwave, several weaker demons gathered around her were crushed into pulp.

A strange, sharp shriek sounded from behind her. A projectile loaded with foul energy shot in from a tricky angle. Vanna moved quickly to her feet, but before she could raise her hand to block it, a fast black figure rushed in from the side. A two-handed greatsword, shining with silver light, intercepted the vicious sneak attack. Then several marine squad members with enchanted steel swords charged in and chopped the demon that had attacked from not far away into thin pieces.

Vanna looked up at the black figure and gave a small nod: “Your reactions are fast.”

Amber’s face lit up with joy. She nodded happily, then could not help looking at Vanna with eyes full of awe and envy: “You really… are even stronger than I imagined.”

“It’s fine. I’m in good shape today,” Vanna said. She gave the alloy greatsword in her hand a casual spin, then drove it backward into the mist beside her, skewering a Abyssal Hound that had just formed out of the thick fog. Her other hand flicked lightly on the hilt—the demon was crushed at

once into fine dust. “And these demons are not very strong… they are much weaker than the enemies I’ve been dealing with lately.”

Amber’s face seemed to freeze for a moment, but she quickly recovered and went back to her position. She kept directing the warriors to clear the wandering demons near the cave entrance while arranging for the fighters to rest in turns and strengthen the defenses.

Vanna also lifted her greatsword again, but just then she seemed to sense something. Her eyes narrowed a little as she looked into the deep fog.

For a moment, she felt as if she had seen a figure—a figure in a tattered robe, hunched over as it walked across the rocky shore in the ravine.

The figure seemed not to notice the fierce fighting around it. It did not see the demons or the Church warriors so close by. It was like a phantom from another layer of time and space, hurrying through the mist.

It lasted only an instant. When Vanna blinked again, the figure was gone.

Right after that, a terrifying demon rose out of the thick fog not far away. It was made from countless bones stacked and woven together, and looked like a three-meter-wide, savage “bone ball”. The hollow howls from inside the sphere forced Vanna to push down her questions for now and raise her sword to meet the enemy…

In a burst of dense musket fire, the strange demons crawling out of the black gate were torn to pieces by the bullets fired by the toy soldiers before their bodies could even settle into shape. Then, with shouted orders and shrill whistles, the toy soldiers, their bodies painted in bright colors, quickly formed up again. They began digging works in the ground and pushed wooden carved cannon carts up into position.

Morris watched this scene with interest. Then he reached down, grabbed one toy soldier from the ground, and lifted it to his eyes to study it. The

metal plate on his forehead slid back. Inside his skull, between countless spinning gears and trembling springs, a set of fine lenses was pushed out by a mechanical arm and focused on the toy soldier.

The toy soldier struggled hard and began to bang the butt of its rifle against Morris's fingers. Wood and metal hit each other with a series of sharp "clang, clang, clang" sounds.

Morris let go of the toy soldier, stretched his fingers, and turned his head to look at the sea witch beside him. She was using a conductor's baton to keep directing all kinds of toy soldiers, paper war chariots, and folded paper soldiers as they set up the lines. He said: "…Quite fierce."

"…Could you stop grabbing my soldiers all the time just to study them?" Lucretia gave Morris a helpless look. "Why don't you go study the demon corpses instead? They're everywhere here…"

"What's so special about demon corpses? We get those on the ship every few days," Morris said. He casually took out a pipe, but as soon as he put it to his mouth he remembered that he was currently in his Forged State, and had to put it back in his pocket with some regret. "When we get the chance, I want to ask you about Doll technology. The way you drive them seems related to the Academy's tech, but it goes in a different direction…"

"Of course, when this is over," Lucretia said easily. "I'm also very interested in the forged body you use. I've dealt with the Truth Academy many times, so I know you have that kind of divine magic that can briefly transform part of your body into machinery. But turning your entire body into a 'forged form'… this is the first time I've seen it."

Morris laughed, a buzzing sound from the springs in his throat. But just then, something caught at the edge of his vision and cut off what he was about to say.

In the depths of the dim cave, on a patch of open ground beside the black gate, a figure seemed to appear out of nowhere.

The figure wore a tattered white robe and looked as if it had been standing there for a very long time. Neither the demons nearby nor the “soldiers” summoned by Lucretia seemed to notice this uninvited guest. The figure just stood there quietly on the battlefield, out of place with its surroundings, like a ghostly image cast in from another layer of time and space.

The figure seemed to be studying the black gate, keeping a fixed stance as it stared at the door without moving.

But it lasted only a moment. When Morris blinked again, that strange figure was gone.

Lucretia suddenly noticed that something was off with Morris. After directing the soldiers to destroy another demon that had crawled out of the black gate, she turned at once: “What is it?”

“…There was a figure near the black gate,” Morris said in a grave tone. “But it vanished in a blink. You didn’t see it?”

“No,” Lucretia shook her head, her brow tightening. “Damn it, I wasn’t looking that way just now…”

“…It’s fine,” Morris said. He glanced at the witch and waved a hand. “I took a picture.”

Lucretia froze for a moment: “A picture…?”

Morris nodded. At the same time, a series of clicks from turning gears and shifting parts sounded inside his body. Then his whole lower jaw joint dropped off in a very unsettling way. A dark opening showed, and from it he slowly spat out a palm-sized piece of photo paper.

Morris pulled out the photo paper and shook it in the air. With his other hand, he casually fixed his jaw back into place. Then he handed the photo to Lucretia: “It’s not very clear. It seems to have been disturbed, but you can still see a white shape.”

Lucretia took the photo with a strange look on her face. She saw the blurry figure near the black gate, but her eyes still drifted back to Morris: “…Why do you even have that function…”

Morris smiled slightly: “I told you, I had many adventures when I was young…”

Lucretia: “…”

…

Duncan had a faint feeling that when he pulled his hand back, something quietly changed. He could not say whether it was his own fate or the future of the world.

He only felt in some deep, unseen place that the decision he made at this moment was very important, whether it turned out good or bad.

He lifted his head and saw that the dark red core still floated calmly right in front of him. The light inside it flickered. The towering “mountain” behind the core had grown quiet, and the lights on its surface looked a little dim.

His refusal had not “angered” this Elder God. It only seemed… puzzled.

After quite a while, the core finally spoke: “Why?”

Then the light inside the core grew a little brighter than before, and it went on: “In theory, seeing the Sanctuary World repaired should match your wishes. You have already saved three city-states, and taking over this world would let all city-states be saved more completely. For quite a long time, they would no longer be under threat from runaway state and corruption. I

have calculated all possible outcomes. You should be glad to see such a result, so why do you refuse?”

Duncan stayed silent for a while, then suddenly asked: “And then?”

The light in the dark red core seemed puzzled: “Then?”

Duncan’s tone stayed calm: “What happens after that ‘quite a long time’ you spoke of?”

The dark red core fell silent. Its slow, flickering glow showed its hesitation.

“I don’t know if there are other plans. Maybe your proposal really is the best choice for now. Maybe things really will go the way you said. But at least for now… I cannot agree to it.”

Duncan spoke calmly as he took a small step back.

“Call it instinct… I feel that there are big problems in your ‘plan’. I think there are other ways, not just resetting this Sanctuary World and letting it drag out a half-life.”

He paused for a moment and looked very seriously at the few rays of light inside the core.

“And just like your reaction a moment ago—it is clear that you cannot tell what will happen after that ‘quite a long time’. Maybe my takeover could truly bring the whole Sanctuary World back to its best state and fix all its current flaws. But even you cannot say how long a Sanctuary World like that, rebuilt and fully in line with its ‘blueprint’, would keep running.

“The Sun that was once thought ‘eternal’ has already gone out twice. The border mist called the ‘Eternal Veil’ has been collapsing again and again for decades. The gods are slowly dying, and you know your own state as well. All things decay. I do not believe that just by sitting in the place of the ancient Elder Kings and the gods I can change that. After all, as a ‘world’

meant for people to live and grow, this Boundless Sea is, in terms of both resources and space, far too… cramped.

“And from a selfish point of view, I do not want to take over everything now only to sit where you sit after another ten thousand years, watching this Sanctuary World fall into the End once again, just like you. When that time comes, who should I look for to ‘take over’ all of this from me?”

Chapter 734: Farewell to The Creator

Duncan’s answer kept that dark red core silent for a long time.

After an unknown time, Shirley and Alice finally heard a low hum from deep within the distant “black mountain range”. As the massive body at the center of the range slowly shifted and writhed, the dark red core of the Abyssal Lord rose bit by bit. It returned to its original place, to the height from which it overlooked the land.

“A Sanctuary World can at least let many people survive, perhaps for several thousand years, perhaps for ten thousand years… Even if it is not eternal, it is better than turning to dust,” the dark red core pulsed faintly, its deep trembling voice echoing across the wasteland. “My Creators told me that survival is the first task, and I have always carried out their orders. In my logic, nothing is more important than keeping the Sanctuary World going.”

“Survival is indeed very important. I understand why you want to keep the Sanctuary World running. But for me… ‘possibility’ is just as necessary. And this ‘Sanctuary World’, as it is now, really does not have enough possibility for me to see a future in it. It…”

Duncan suddenly fell silent. In that silence, his gaze swept over Dog at his side and Shirley, who still kept the form of a Abyssal demon.

The great fire of Pland, the mud of Frostholm, the nightmare of Lightwind Harbor, the priests, soldiers, and commoners who died, the fallen and the

martyrs, the limited Boundless Sea, and every explorer who was trapped to death in this Boundless Sea…

Duncan slowly closed his eyes. Memories rose and tangled in his mind, then finally turned into a sigh: "…It's too dark."

The dark red core that overlooked the land spoke quietly: "Then do you have a better plan?"

"No. But I have some vague ideas." Duncan opened his eyes and calmly met the core's gaze, as if staring into a giant eye worn down by ages. "I more or less know what I should do and what I can do. But I haven't found a correct and workable way yet. I'm still searching – for a future better than this 'Sanctuary World', a future with more possibility, a future worth looking forward to."

"…Is it eternal?" the dark red core asked, still calm.

"No. Nothing in this world is truly eternal. All things decay. But at least it shouldn't be a sea shrouded in fog, short of resources, where you can hardly find a place to stand. That so-called 'eternal Veil' at the border… it is far too narrow for civilization."

"You should know we don't have much time. Neither you nor I, nor this 'Sanctuary World', have time to waste," the dark red core said, its light slowly brightening and dimming. "How long will you take to find that way out? And what if, in the end, you still haven't found it?"

Duncan was silent for a moment, then lifted his head and calmly met the gaze of the Abyssal Lord.

"…Before the world collapses, I will come back here. If by then I still haven't found another way out, I will take over all of this."

After a brief silence, the ancient Navigation Mainframe let out a low tremor. "Recorded. Then this is our pact. If, in the end, you still cannot find

a plan better than prolonging the Sanctuary World, come back here and ignite me. And if I have already entered a full runaway state before that… show no mercy. Burn me until nothing is left."

Duncan nodded slowly. "We have a deal."

After that, the Abyssal Lord grew quiet again. Its core hung high above the peak. The faint light within it flickered at a rhythm that slowly matched the lights scattered along the surrounding mountains, as if it was engaged in a long and deep thought, recalculating the future and everything in this world.

Duncan did not disturb this ancient Navigation Mainframe. Time passed, who knew how long, before that deep trembling voice suddenly sounded again: "Navigator Three."

Alice did not move. She did not realize it was calling her until Duncan suddenly tapped her arm. Only then did the doll jerk in surprise. "Ah… huh? Me?"

"…It seems you have completely forgotten the New Hope, haven't you?"

Alice listened, then raised a hand to scratch her hair. Her face looked a bit awkward and guilty. "Uh… sorry, I really don't remember… Was I supposed to remember at least something?"

"No, this is good. It is not what I planned at first, but you are still alive. Survival comes above all. Please keep on living, and do everything you can to help the Flame Usurper."

Alice thought for a second, then took a moment to do the math in her head. She nodded half a beat late. "Oh… mm-hmm! Of course, I'll definitely help the captain!"

Beside them, Shirley tilted her head back. She and Dog gazed up together at that awe-inspiring ancient Creator, so grand it could drive every great explorer and scholar in the world mad in both body and mind.

They could tell the time to say farewell had come. They suddenly felt they also had questions they wanted to ask, yet they could not think of a single thing to say.

But the “gaze” of that dark red core already seemed to fall upon them.

It was a feeling hard to describe. The faint light inside the dark red core only pulsed as usual, yet Shirley felt, by pure instinct, that the other side was now turning its gaze upon her.

A strange sense of being completely seen through rose in her heart. She stepped back half a step without thinking. Then she heard that deep trembling voice again. This time it sounded a little gentler.

“This world has brought you a great deal of suffering,” that gentle voice said slowly. “Do you… also think this Sanctuary World is awful?”

Shirley opened her mouth. She did not know how to answer that. She thought that someone more learned, quicker, and wiser should be standing here now.

Someone like Old Mr. Morris, that Grand Scholar. As the first “mortal” to stand face to face with the Abyssal Lord, the one answering now should have been someone far more capable than her.

Not someone as ignorant and uneducated as she was.

But that Elder God still waited quietly for her answer.

“…I…” Shirley finally squeezed out a sound from her throat. The bone limbs behind her shifted uneasily, and the wisp of light in her chest flickered faintly. “I don’t know either… I didn’t really understand what you and the captain were talking about…”

She muttered, then hesitated for a long time before whispering, “It is hard to stay alive. Sometimes you worry about food. Sometimes it is winter clothes

and fuel. Where I used to live, the nights were not very safe either… But I think no matter what happens, there will always be some people who live in hardship. Even if the city-states become ten times bigger and there is more than enough food, life will still be hard in other ways.

“My old neighbor used to say this all the time. Life always has bitter parts. It’s not the world’s fault, and it’s not because someone did something wrong. Compared to that, what the captain cares about is more…”

She turned her head a little and stole a look at Duncan, then quickly pulled her gaze back.

“The captain cares about things that are more… ‘profound’. I don’t really understand them, but I think what he says must be right, and it must be better for many more people. As for me, I don’t have many demands for the future. I just hope… I can live safely and steadily. Of course, if it is possible…”

She stopped suddenly, as if she was choosing her words very carefully. After a long hesitation, she spoke in a small voice, “I hope there won’t be any more demons running out to hurt people. I hope no more people vanish in the corners. I hope the Sun rises and sets every day, and the thick fog doesn’t eat people… That would be even better. If all that could really come true, then anything is fine.”

Dog slowly leaned closer and rubbed his bony, fearsome head softly against Shirley’s leg.

The dark red core hanging high above was silent for a long time. Then it finally broke the silence in a soft voice. “I understand.”

With a series of low rumbles, the center of the huge star-shaped mountain range slowly split open. The dark red core of the Abyssal Lord began to sink back into the depths of the mountain, bit by bit.

Duncan knew the time to say goodbye had come.

But before the core vanished completely into the “mountain”, he suddenly took a step forward. “One more thing.”

The core stopped and waited for him.

“The guard of the last Critt outpost asked me to bring you a greeting,” Duncan said as he took another step forward. His expression grew solemn, and his tone became very serious. “He said… they were honored to have completed their work.”

The dark red core stayed still. For a few seconds, there was no sound at all. No one knew what this ancient Navigation Mainframe was thinking or calculating at that moment.

Maybe it had searched its vast database and found the meaning of the distant word “Critt”. Maybe it was recalling information from the Dawn of Creation. Maybe… it was just a silent sigh.

Or perhaps, the Creator who had made all things and the Critt clan also thought of Its own Creators at that moment.

“I was also honored… to have worked with them.”

The dark red core slowly sank into the depths of the mountain range.

Duncan drew back his gaze from the “mountain”. He took a light breath. Layers of illusory flames began to rise and ripple around him. “We should go. There is still much to do.”

Alice walked to the captain’s side and stepped forward to meet the encircling flames. Shirley moved her long bone limbs and stepped into the fire with Dog.

The flames rose. In Alice’s pale violet eyes, countless tangled paths appeared, as she began to search for the correct route out of the depths of

the Abyssal Deep.

Shirley still stared, dazed, at the distant peak, at the place where the dark red core had vanished. For some reason, she kept feeling… that a gaze still rested on her from there.

Only when the flames closed around them, and the light and shadow outside the fire grew vague and hazy, did she suddenly hear a faint whisper. The voice seemed to echo directly in her mind. It repeated a few times before she finally heard the words clearly –

“…I am sorry. I did my best back then…”

The flames shot upward, then vanished in an instant into the vast gloom of the Deep Sea of the Abyssal Deep.

Chapter 735: Quiet Changes

The cold, frozen projections of the cluster of Starry Sky caves swept quickly past the edge of their vision. Navigation Mainframe-Alice calculated the route home. Shirley, who had returned to human form, stared in a daze with Dog at the shifting lights beyond the flames and stayed silent for a long time.

After a very long while, Duncan's voice suddenly reached her ears. "What are you thinking about?"

Shirley jumped in fright. Then she blinked her eyes, those Abyssal demon eyes filled with a blood-red glow, and muttered softly, "I just suddenly thought of something… I always thought the Abyssal Lord was a terrifying Eldritch God, in a runaway state, really, really bad…"

Duncan looked at her for a few seconds, then drew his gaze back. "If you had faced Him alone today, things would have been exactly as you say. Your mind would not have been able to understand or handle His voice, and you would only have seen His runaway state madness. It is the same for the other deities. In the end, what you 'saw' of the Abyssal Lord today was actually from my point of view."

"Mm, I know. Dog explained this to me before, after you met with the Pope of the Four Gods. Cognitive Shift… right?"

Duncan nodded and said nothing for a moment. Ten-odd seconds passed before he suddenly spoke again. "Do you think I should have accepted the Abyssal Lord's invitation?"

Shirley froze, as if she had not kept up. “…Huh?”

Duncan still looked at her gently. “If I had accepted, then all the things you hope for could come true almost at once. No more demons would run out to hurt people. No more people would vanish in the corners. The Sun would rise and set every day. The thick fog would not eat people.

“The world you long for, where many more people can live in safety and peace, would be there as soon as I took over the Sanctuary World.

“Maybe it would last a thousand years, maybe ten thousand, or even longer. After I take control of this world, every city-state will be as safe as Pland and Frostholm are now. Even the nights will quiet down. As long as my flames keep burning, this Boundless Sea can keep its peaceful look, until all resources are used up and the Sanctuary World reaches the limit of the lifespan it was designed for. That is the true lifespan the Abyssal Lord once planned, but never reached.”

Shirley was quiet for a moment, then spoke softly. “And then… everyone would still die, right?”

Duncan looked at her calmly. “Yes. But that would be after a very long time. Even if you remained immortal like a normal Abyssal demon, by then you should have no regrets left.”

This time Shirley stayed quiet even longer. She seemed to be trying hard to think it through. Dog stayed peacefully at her side, and it was hard to tell what he was thinking.

“Actually…” After a long time, Shirley finally broke the silence. “Actually, I really don’t understand it all. I think the Abyssal Lord’s plan is already very good. A safe Sanctuary World. It might not be eternal, but at least it is safe. I… don’t have such high hopes. Being able to live the last stretch of

time in peace like that, isn't that enough? After all… there is nowhere else to go."

"Yes, there is nowhere else to go," Duncan said softly. "Because this world is forever only this one Boundless Sea, forever only these city-states floating on the ocean, forever only this little patch of living space in the mist…

"But Shirley, the real 'world' shouldn't be like this. This is just… a narrow cardboard box."

Shirley listened on the side, only half understanding. Chains clinked softly as Dog shifted and finally broke the silence. "Just like you said, this little box cannot bear any more 'possibility', can it?"

"It is too narrow. The Boundless Sea locked in fog is very narrow. Even a few thousand or ten thousand years of 'service life' is very narrow. For the countless civilizations destroyed in the Great Annihilation, this little box is only big enough to cram in a small part of their replicas. And the limited life of the Sanctuary World is not even enough time for them to patch together their lost history once…

"This is not a 'new home', do you understand? If the 'world' before the Great Annihilation was made of many lush forests, then the Boundless Sea now is only a small potted plant. The result of the first three Long Nights was only to take a few flowers and grasses that survived in the forest, plant them in the pot, and pretend the forest still exists.

"But in truth, no matter how you water and fertilize it, it will never become a forest. Never. And it would only take one small mistake for even the flower pot to be lost as well."

"So you refused His plan because you can already see it has no future," Dog said slowly. "You already know another way to solve this, don't you?"

Duncan did not answer. He only lowered his head and quietly looked at his own hands.

He blinked. In the instant his eyelids closed, in the first 0.002 seconds of darkness, he saw clusters of stars flicker. Magnificent rivers of stars shone in the deep sky. Huge star-forming clouds stretched between them like splendid curtains.

Even though he had already left that cavern, he could still see that “different scenery” in the first 0.002 seconds every time he blinked.

Duncan knew he was undergoing some kind of change. Those things that used to be hidden, now appearing in his sight, were only one part of that change. As for when exactly this change had started… he did not know.

But he knew that as long as he kept seeking the truth and tried to uncover the secret of his own existence, this change would keep appearing, keep growing, and keep speeding up…

He did not know if he was ready, but he knew there was no time left to prepare. Just like Navigator One had said, neither he nor this world had any time left.

The phantom of distant starlight reached its end…

A sea of blooming flowers burst open in the illusion. The short Conductor’s Baton in Lucretia’s hand fell lightly. A few crisp notes sprang out, and the Fear Demons buried under the flowers turned, soundless, into drifting ash.

Beside her came the hiss of pressurized pipes and a loud clang of metal. Morris punched away a Abyssal Hound that had leaped at him and shook his head with a helpless look. “These demons have no respect at all for knowledge and wisdom… Good thing I still know a bit of boxing.”

“The number of demons is increasing,” Lucretia said, her face serious as she watched the black gate that was still swelling and writhing. For once, a

trace of tiredness showed on her face. “The crack is expanding. More and more demons are noticing this place. The whole island is sinking toward the Deep Sea of the Abyssal Deep.”

“The captain should be back soon,” Morris muttered, his throat giving off the metallic resonance caused by vibrating reeds. “Judging from the noise above, if the captain doesn’t come back soon, Vanna might just smash the whole valley open.”

Lucretia frowned and tilted her head, listening to the heavy booms that kept coming from the dome of the cavern. She shook her head slightly. “That doesn’t sound like Miss Vanna’s doing. It sounds more like the Sacred Island itself… It’s about to be ‘woken up’ again.”

Morris opened his mouth to speak, but before he could say anything, a bright green flame suddenly surged up from the writhing black gate.

In the blink of an eye, the fire spewed out from the portal and formed a spinning gate of flames in the open space of the cavern. A few figures stepped out of it, and the captain’s familiar, solemn voice came with them. “You’re right. This place is about to ‘wake up’ again. Tell everyone to evacuate the Sacred Island. Our work here is done.”

Lucretia was startled for a moment, then reacted at once. She did not even bother with greetings and nodded right away. “Got it, Dad!”

Before her words had even fully fallen, she was already moving quickly to gather up her Toy soldiers. After saluting the captain, Morris at once saw Shirley and Dog standing beside him. He noticed Shirley’s blood-red eyes, just like those of a Abyssal demon, and his eyes widened a little. “Shirley, what is…”

But Shirley’s eyes were even wider than Morris’s. She stared blankly at the Grand Scholar in his current “forged” state and finally squeezed out a line.

“Old Gentleman, why did you turn into copper?”

Duncan also looked at Morris with some surprise and gave a small, thoughtful nod. “…A very special form.”

Only then did Morris realize he was still in his forged form. He hurried to focus his mind, silently recited Rahm’s prayer, and cast divine magic to reverse his state.

The feeling of a copper shell faded quickly from his whole body. Living flesh replaced gears, bearings, pumps, and copper tubes in a way that was hard to believe. A pair of ruby focus lenses slipped back out of his eye sockets, and human eyeballs grew there instead. He blinked, pulled the delicate brass mechanism out from inside his body, and finally smiled and nodded. “…The power of knowledge.”

Shirley was completely dumbfounded. “…That’s not what you and the captain meant by ‘the power of knowledge’ when you taught me…”

In such a short time, this young lady had completely relearned what “knowledge changes fate” and “the power of knowledge” could mean. She would probably never forget it for the rest of her life.

At that moment, another wave of strange howls and mutters suddenly rose in the cavern.

The writhing black gate grew restless again. More demons began to push through the crack into the Mortal Realm, their jagged bones and countless hands, feet, and tentacles squeezing out from the moving surface and crawling toward the cavern.

Lucretia raised her short Conductor’s Baton on instinct, but before she could act, Duncan waved a hand at the gate. “Go back.”

The jagged bones and countless hands, feet, and tentacles began to scramble back through the portal in a rush.

“And close the door on your way,” Duncan added from the side.

The swelling, writhing “black gate” slowly grew calm.

Lucretia: “…”

Duncan turned his head, waved to the Sea Witch to bring her back to her senses, and said, “Come on. We still have a lot to do.”

Chapter 736: Leaving Sanctuary Island

The “Black Gate” deep in the cavern had been closed, yet more and more Abyssal demons were still crawling out all across Sanctuary Island. This little island, formed from a piece of the Abyssal Lord’s flesh, was trembling. Deep rumbles and strange buzzing sounds rolled through the mist like noises from a giant beast’s belly. Countless weird shapes flickered in and out of sight in the fog. Every second, shadows turned solid and wildly attacked the uninvited guests who had stepped onto the island.

Duncan and his group left the cavern. After they met up safely with Vanna, Amber, and the others who had been holding the valley, they began to fall back toward the coast.

The ground shook. From deep in the valley came the sharp crack and boom of breaking rock. Chaotic howls and mad muttering spread like a nightmare in every direction. Nameless shadows gathered in the mist. Cold air carried malice from all sides as it howled past the jagged stones on the cliffs. In the swirling fog, even the rocks on the cliff faces seemed to slowly come to life. Huge limbs hung down from the heights. Those vine-like limbs bent and shivered, making wet swallowing and chewing sounds. Dirty black mud dripped from them, and every drop that hit the ground hissed and sent up curls of dark smoke.

Even the Church warriors, who often operated in the border seas, could not help feeling tense. The marines gripped their enchanted steel swords,

consecrated lanterns, and charm amulets as they moved, watching the restless shadows along the path. Amber walked beside Vanna with a longsword in one hand and, in the other, a consecrated lantern carved with storm sigils. As she walked she softly recited prayers to the Storm Goddess. Gentle wave?sounds whispered in the minds of the warriors, shielding their thoughts so they would not be tempted or corrupted by the demons' whispers. The death priest, whose body was covered in tattoos, walked at the very front carrying a casket of Sacred Bone Ash. Beside him the fog briefly drew back, and the shapes of the demons faded. A temporarily calm road opened before them for the journey back.

Once Duncan saw that these Church warriors truly had enough strength to handle the trouble on the road and bring everyone back safely, he relaxed. He walked calmly at the back of the group and put more of his energy into thinking.

After some time, they made it through the wild inner part of the island and finally stepped onto the main road leading to the pier—the coast was already close.

The roar of guns and explosions came from deep within the fog ahead. Now and then huge flames leapt up into the air, like a bursting sunrise that lit and burned red a wide stretch of sky. The sight was shocking.

Amber came over and said: "replicas shaped like ships and large wandering demons have already started showing up on the sea nearby. Our fleet is fighting those monsters." The young priest of the Goddess held a longsword in one hand and, in the other, a consecrated lantern carved with storm patterns. Her face looked very serious. "They report that one side of Sanctuary Island is slowly… changing shape. Some of the sea cliffs seem to be softening and collapsing downward. It has not affected this side yet, but the whole island is clearly… coming to life, in some way."

Duncan lifted his head. He looked at the huge boulders in the mountains that kept coming alive in the mist, and at the black tentacles that had grown from the nearby slopes and were curling and spreading toward the low ground. He nodded lightly.

“This island is just as Shirley said. It really is a piece of the Abyssal Lord’s flesh. The whole island is a section of one of His tentacles that pierced into the Mortal Realm,” Duncan said. “And now it seems He has started to correct that ‘mistake’.”

“…It is a pity about all the truths buried here,” Amber pressed her lips together and said: “If we had more time, we could have explored this island properly. Those Annihilators sat here for at least a few centuries. There must still be countless dark and sinful secrets hidden here… maybe even secret bases and lists of their agents hidden inside the city?states…”

Hearing Amber mutter with a bit of regret, Duncan did not answer. He only watched the island as it kept collapsing and twisting, and could not help recalling the vast ‘mountain range’ he had seen at the bottom of the Abyssal Deep—majestic, grand, and yet shrouded in sorrow and darkness.

Ten thousand years had passed. The “Navigator One” that had once been meant to rebuild the ecosystem had, in its runaway growth, turned into a huge twisted monster. Its limbs pierced the Abyssal Deep Sea, stabbed into Subspace, and reached into the Mortal Realm, yet it still had not stopped growing.

This made Duncan think that even if the Boundless Sea had never “malfunctioned”, even if Vision 001 – the Sun could keep supporting it, the ever?growing Navigator One alone would still have been enough to bring another doomsday.

And that doomsday would not be far away. Perhaps, on some day within the next hundred years, Navigator One’s exponentially growing body would fill

the whole Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea. Then it would spread at a mad speed into every dimension. His tentacles would stab through every city? state and coil over the whole sea, wrapping around every ship that sailed there, until every solid thing in the mortal world was swallowed again by its "creator" and turned once more into black mud and writhing tentacles.

…Was this the same scene those Annihilators saw in their visions of mental derangement? Just as they preached—on some day in the future, the Abyssal Lord would return to this pitiful world. The elements would burst up from the depths of the world and turn everything back into a pure, original state…

In a way, those mad cultists really had seen part of this world's "truth" in their mental derangement. Maybe it was during brief links with the Abyssal Lord. Maybe it happened while they turned themselves into demons and touched the elements as they pleased. They had seen the future and then explained that terrible future in whatever way they were willing to understand.

Duncan drew in a slow breath and gently shook his head.

Navigator One had invited him to "take over" this Sanctuary World and hoped that, in the process, Duncan would burn away his huge body that had already gone completely out of control. Navigator One had calmly admitted that this would be a kind of "release"—release from a long mission.

It seemed that sustaining this Sanctuary World really was a long and bitter task, enough to leave even an ancient "machine" tired and filled with despair.

In his heart, Duncan once again firmed his resolve to find another way.

Keeping this Sanctuary World as it was would never be a good choice—at least, it was not the best one.

After a journey that was dangerous but ended without disaster, the landing party finally returned to the hidden pier, shielded by the inner bay and the sea cliffs. The small boats they had used to come here still waited at the shore, rocking in the restless water.

The landing skiff lowered from the Vanished rocked the most—and it was rocking upright.

In short, the whole boat had its bow pointed at the sky, stuck in the shallows like a weed, bouncing and swaying. Only when Duncan and the others showed up did it finally flop back onto the water with a loud “bang”. Then it wagged its oars, swung its stern, and rushed to the shore on its own, bobbing in excitement and slapping its own sides with the oars.

Duncan: “…”

Lucretia stared at the little boat for a while, then lowered her head and muttered to Duncan: “Dad, I kind of don’t want to get on that boat anymore…”

“It is a bit embarrassing,” Duncan stayed silent for a few seconds, then sighed softly. “But let’s still get on. We’ve already come this far. If we take the pigeons right in front of it, this thing might just sink itself on the spot. There are already enough ghost ships in this world. If we add one more furious landing skiff to the list, it will be hard to explain to people later…”

Lucretia sighed and, with mixed feelings, could only follow Father onto the small boat.

The three fast boats left the pier and sped toward the mouth of the small bay, toward the thick fog that kept flashing with light and booming with noise.

Just as they left the bay’s mouth and could already see several main warships anchored on the nearby sea, Shirley suddenly seemed to feel

something. She jerked around on the small boat and looked back toward the island.

Her eyes, filled with a faint bloody light, slowly widened—

“ The island is starting to sink!”

In a series of dull, thunder?like booms, the whole Sanctuary Island collapsed and sagged like some soft matter that had lost its support. Its sea cliffs melted downward. Black sludge seeped out from every bit of soil and rock. Huge tentacles and jagged limbs burst through the softening cliffs and coast, thrashing madly in the rising water. Countless frenzied demons ran and howled among the crumbling rock walls. They seemed to want to escape, but some unseen force tugged at them so they could not leave the bounds of Sanctuary Island. They could only “sink” along with the island…

Duncan noticed that Sanctuary Island was not really sinking into the sea. Instead, it was dissolving, melting away at the surface of the water.

Navigator One was slowly pulling back this limb that had wrongly stretched into the Mortal Realm.

Even though the collapse of the Sanctuary World was already close at hand and his own runaway state could no longer be reversed, he still tried, within the limits of his power, to repair the system’s errors and push back the final breaking point.

But… how many more times could this kind of delay still work?

Duncan and Alice sat at the stern of the small boat and looked back at Sanctuary Island, which was almost completely “dissolved” into the sea. Its final outline shook in the thickening fog like a dream that was slowly drifting away.

Before that outline fully vanished, Duncan faintly heard a voice. It was a low vibration carried on the breeze.

“Do not forget our pact, bearer of the Flame Usurper…”

Duncan felt someone grab his arm. He turned his head. In the fog, the clearest thing he saw was Alice’s deep violet eyes.

“I heard him speaking, Captain.”

“I heard him too, Alice. Can you still find the place where he is?”

“Yes,” Alice nodded, then scratched her hair. “But I don’t really know how I do it. I just feel that… if you need it, I can still take you to him, because I remember… the ‘road’.”

Duncan nodded slightly. “That is enough.”

Alice hesitated for a moment and then asked, very carefully: “Then… will we go back to find him?”

“I think… we will.”

“Then about when?”

“…At least before the world’s doomsday.”

Chapter 737: Keywords

The fleet sailed back toward the fog boundary along the route they had used to come. Maybe because the large solid mass of Sanctuary Island had sunk, the nearby sea was far from calm. The surface, which usually looked like a mirror, now rippled again and again with fine, fish?scale?like waves. The thick fog around them also kept showing strange and colorful illusions. It made many people tense.

But until they had gone halfway, nothing truly threatening appeared in the fog.

The spirit form sail hung high. Now and then, faint creaks sounded as the ropes shifted. Thin mist flowed over the deck of the Vanished. In the pale haze, Agatha’s figure faintly appeared as she walked slowly through the fog.

She was checking the “environment” around the Vanished. In her eyes, the scenes of both the Mortal Realm and the Spirit Realm were reflected at the same time. The fog around them did not look quite the same as when they came. The Spirit Realm also seemed faintly restless. It did not seem likely to affect the Vanished, but she still cared about it and stayed on guard.

Everyone else had gathered in the cabin. The captain was talking with his followers about the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea.

In front of the crew members he trusted, Duncan did not hide his experiences in the Abyssal Deep and the Deep Sea, including his conversation with the Abyssal Lord.

Morris sat by the long table with a pipe between his teeth. Thin threads of smoke drifted up, showing how uneasy he felt. After a long time, the old scholar finally put the pipe down and muttered, his expression odd: “I have seen many unbelievable things in my life, but nothing like this. The Creator of this world actually invited you to take His place…”

Nina pinched her own arm hard, as if she still doubted she was awake. Then she looked up at Duncan and asked: “You really turned Him down?”

Duncan’s face stayed calm. “Yes. The Abyssal Lord’s plan has serious problems, so I refused.”

“Does the Sanctuary World really have no future…” Lucretia murmured to herself. She seemed to recall a talk she had once had with Father. After a long pause, she spoke softly: “I still remember the question you asked me. You asked whether I felt this Boundless Sea was narrow and cramped. But now it seems that even this already cramped Sanctuary World has reached its limit. I never thought that, after we left the civilized world and came all this way, this would be the news we received.”

A slightly heavy mood hung over the cabin. The long table fell silent for a time. After a while, Nina leaned close to Shirley and asked in a low, worried voice: “How do you feel now? Is anything wrong?”

“Actually I don’t feel much different from usual. My eyes and ears even seem sharper than before,” Shirley muttered. Her eyes still shone with a bloody light. “It’s just that, when I think about having to cover my eyes or keep them shut every time I go into a city from now on… it sounds really bothersome.”

“At least you came back safely,” Nina could not help grumbling. “I was so worried when I heard you were missing. I even wanted to go up on the island to look for you, but Goathead stopped me…”

Listening to the quiet talk beside him, Duncan slowly let his gaze move over each figure at the table. His tense expression eased a little, and he let out a soft breath.

“Let’s stop here. This trip to Sanctuary Island was very draining. Before we return to the city?state, everyone should rest well.”

As he finished speaking, he was already standing. He waved a hand to tell the others not to get up, then turned and left.

The captain left. Until his figure vanished at the doorway, the cabin stayed quietly heavy. Only after a while did Nina mutter and break the silence: “Uncle Duncan looks really tired… he has a lot on his mind.”

“He has to think about too many things,” Morris said as he put out his pipe. “Sadly, there is very little we can help with.”

After thinking for a moment, Lucretia turned her eyes to Dog and asked: “Did Father say anything else after he turned down the Abyssal Lord’s ‘plan’?”

Dog thought for a while and then spoke, not very sure: “He said he had another plan, but right now it is only an idea. He hasn’t found the right path yet… That’s all. He didn’t say anything more, and he didn’t explain it to me or Shirley.”

Listening to Dog, Lucretia fell into thought…

After leaving the cabin, Duncan did not go anywhere else. He went straight across the mid?deck to the door of the captain’s cabin at the stern.

In the thin mist drifting slowly across the deck, the dark wooden door stood before him as always. The words “Door of the Lost Ones” on the doorframe were sharp and clear.

Duncan put his hand on the doorknob, then suddenly stopped and simply stood there. In a brief moment of thought, he lifted his head and watched the pale fog outside the rail, stacked like layers of curtains, and the hazy daylight that fell through it. He stood like that for a long time.

After who knew how long, he finally drew back his gaze and pushed the door open.

Passing through the familiar door, stepping onto the familiar floor, and walking into the familiar room, Zhou Ming let out a quiet breath and strolled through the living room.

Everything in the studio apartment was just as he remembered, as if it would never change—as if not only the past few years or decades, but even the past thousands and tens of thousands of years had all been the same.

Everything here was etched deep in Zhou Ming's mind. He walked past the furnishings that were familiar beyond all measure and stepped up to the window. He looked out through the glass that had never once been opened and stared at the view outside.

Pale mist hung like layers of curtains. In the fog no trace of what should have been "streets" could be seen. Only hazy daylight fell from above and spread through the vapor.

Zhou Ming hesitated for a moment, then slowly reached toward the window and pressed his hand against the glass.

Cold, hard glass met his touch. The window, as always, did not move at all, as if it had set solid with the space around it.

He drew a gentle breath, then slowly blinked.

In the instant his eyelids closed, in the first 0.002 seconds of the coming darkness, he… saw nothing at all.

There was no window, no fog outside, and no so?called “true side” of the world in his sight.

In front of him there was only endless darkness, an ultimate void in which everything had perished.

Zhou Ming slowly stepped back two steps and steadied his breathing.

He remembered the changes that had happened to him. He remembered that, whenever he moved on the “other side” of the door, each blink gave him a 0.002?second glimpse of the “true landscape” hidden beneath the Mortal Realm. So why, here, did he see only utter darkness made of absolute nothing?

Was it because, here, he was “Zhou Ming” and not “Duncan”? Because this room belonged to some higher level of existence? Or was it because, here, there truly was… nothing at all?

Zhou Ming stood in the living room, lost in thought. Then, out of the corner of his eye, he noticed a patch of light in the room.

It was his computer. The machine whose power cord had already been pulled out was humming along, and the monitor was playing a looping wallpaper as always.

Zhou Ming frowned a little, as if something had come to mind. He quickly walked over and sat down in front of the computer.

He moved the mouse and closed the wallpaper, then opened the browser and began typing in the search bar. He had not used it for so long that his fingers were clumsy. He mistyped several times before slowly getting his feel back.

He still remembered that, once before, the browser on this computer had given him an answer. It had shown “the Moon”, and in some way that reply had really explained part of the world’s “truth” to him.

Would it answer his other questions again?

As the soft clack of keys sounded, he first typed “0.002 seconds” into the search box and pressed Enter.

He watched the spinning cursor and the slowly moving progress bar with uneasy eyes while his thoughts churned.

Navigator One had told him that he had come to this world at the very start of the Great Annihilation. The ancient Elder Kings had gathered around him and seen a chaotic Light Cocoon floating at the center of the ashes. Was that Light Cocoon this “studio apartment” of his?

If so, then what did all the furnishings and items in this studio apartment represent?

What did this computer represent? What about the shelves at the far end of the room? And those “models” that had been burned by flames and transformed into what they were now—what did they stand for?

The cursor flashed. The progress bar at the bottom of the screen suddenly emptied, and an error message from the browser appeared before Zhou Ming’s eyes.

But he was not surprised.

After a brief pause for thought, he typed new words into the search box: “Great Annihilation”.

The browser errored out. The search failed.

Zhou Ming was not discouraged. After a moment’s thought, he entered another keyword: “End of Time”.

Another error followed. Then came more keywords—

“cosmic collision”, “redshift”, “Sanctuary World”, “ancient Elder Kings”, “Deep Sea era”, “the stars”…

He tried one keyword after another, but the error message on the screen never changed.

After trying who knew how many times, Zhou Ming slowly began to frown. When the last keyword—“Zhou Ming”—brought yet another error, he let out a soft sigh, and a wave of disappointment rose in his heart.

“It” had not responded to him. It had given no answers.

Not sure whether he felt more frustrated or empty, Zhou Ming shook his head and leaned back in the chair, staring at the screen with tired eyes.

The little cursor still flashed in the search bar, as if it were waiting for him to type another keyword—or silently mocking him.

Zhou Ming sat there quietly for more than ten minutes. Then, all of a sudden, he stared hard at the tiny flashing cursor as something seemed to leap into his mind.

He sat up straight at once, put his hands on the keyboard again, and typed another keyword—

“Inverse Singularity”

In the instant he pressed Enter, a phantom roar suddenly crashed into Zhou Ming’s mind, and the screen before his eyes fell into darkness.

Chapter 738: The Knock on the Door

A phantom rumble suddenly sounded. The screen in front of him went completely black. In the next second, Zhou Ming felt all sound pull away from him—the computer's fan went quiet, the hum of the fridge in the corner slowly faded, and the whole room fell into a strange dead silence. The air around him… was changing.

And all of this happened right after he typed the words "Inverse Singularity" into the search bar.

He blinked, pushed his chair back, and stood up from the computer desk.

The chair slid backward without a sound. His movements made no sound either. A pen by the edge of the desk was bumped off and fell to the floor, but even when it landed, it was completely silent.

For a few short seconds, Zhou Ming even thought he had gone deaf.

Then he realized the problem was with the environment around him—the room was getting darker.

The lights vanished. Everything in the room slowly became covered in a layer of chaotic shadows. In the deepening gloom, all things began to lose their color. The patterned curtains first turned into a gray-white block. Then his desk, his chair, and his bed followed. Everything in sight turned one after another into dull gray, then was slowly swallowed by the thick darkness that surged upward…

It was as if the many units of a huge system were shutting down one by one. In just over ten seconds, the “room” in Zhou Ming’s eyes turned into a murky, chaotic space. When even the walls around him disappeared, true darkness filled his vision.

Zhou Ming stood where he was and looked around. In this sudden darkness, he felt a strange… familiarity, and an odd sense of comfort.

After a while, his “sight” seemed to adapt to the dim environment. In the depths of the chaos, some faint shapes caught his attention.

Zhou Ming hesitated for a moment. Then, from the positions and distances of those shapes, he suddenly thought of something. He at once stepped toward them.

In the deep, dark chaos, several things appeared before his eyes—lifelike “models,” floating where the end of the room should have been.

The Vanished, the White Oak, Pland, Frostholm…

And the “World Tree” turning slowly in midair—Atlantis.

They floated in this endless darkness, in a space that looked as if it had already gone through Universal Extinction, as though they were the only things left in this “world.”

Zhou Ming stared blankly at these “collectibles” drifting around him. His thoughts surged. Countless questions and guesses rose in his mind.

Why? What did this mean? What was this trying to tell him?

Atlantis, like a floating potted plant, slowly spun in the dark. As if by accident, she drifted to the front of Zhou Ming. Some of her branches stretched out gently into the void. It seemed as if she was sensing the surroundings—or maybe she was just growing without any awareness.

Zhou Ming looked at this little World Tree, hesitated for a second, then reached a finger toward her.

The moment he reached out, he suddenly noticed that his body had changed at some unknown point—starlight had replaced his flesh and blood. Dense river-like star streams and bright nebulae filled his body like mist. The stars inside him were frozen in place, just like that ancient Starry Sky phantom above the dome of the Abyssal Deep.

But the two still seemed different.

Zhou Ming stared in shock at his arm. Before he could think further, his fingertip had already touched one of the World Tree's extended branches.

In an instant, information too vast for any human mind to understand poured into his "head." In that storm of rushing fragments, he felt as if he were blinking his way through an endlessly long span of years, through an endlessly long journey—primordial gods, the first living beings, giant trees, forests, rivers, mountains, civilizations, memories…

Zhou Ming suddenly stepped back half a step. The storm of information faded at once. He opened his eyes in the darkness and saw that Atlantis was still spinning freely in place. Branches stretching from the edge of her crown would now and then flick the White Oak, sometimes flick Pland, and sometimes flick Frostholm…

Zhou Ming stared for several seconds before he came back to himself. Looking at the scene before him, he muttered in a strange tone: "Atlantis, don't bully your roommates."

Then he lifted his head and looked again at the boundless darkness ahead.

Before the "room" vanished, this should have been the wall where the shelves stood, the end of his tiny apartment, the barrier that kept him trapped here—it was the shell of the "cocoon."

But now the entire room was gone. The darkness here seemed to stretch on without end.

Zhou Ming hesitated for a moment, then slowly got up and walked toward that darkness. He raised a hand and felt around in the dark before him. He moved very carefully, as if afraid he might run into the wall from his memory.

Luckily, he was careful.

Because almost at once, he ran into an invisible barrier—something hard and cold in the darkness blocked his way. He felt his arm bump into that barrier. Then he pushed at it with more force and found that it did not move at all.

The room had vanished, but the shell of the “cocoon” was still there. He still could not leave. The darkness that looked boundless was only a part of that hard outer shell.

Zhou Ming stopped in front of the invisible shell. After knocking on it a few times in vain, he gave up. He turned around and looked back the way he had come.

All the furniture in the room had disappeared, including the computer. Only a single door still stood quietly in the depths of the darkness. It was the only “exit” from this space.

“Can anyone explain this?” After who knew how long in silence, Zhou Ming suddenly spoke. He asked the darkness, and although he knew this kind of “talking to himself” might look a bit foolish, he still said very seriously: “Is this some kind of ‘answer’?”

No one in the darkness answered him.

After a while, he spoke again: “Is this an explanation of the keyword ‘Inverse Singularity’? Or is it just some kind of unclear ‘demonstration,’

meant to help me understand my own nature or what I can do?”

The darkness stayed silent.

“Can anyone give a detailed explanation—what are you trying to do by sending a 0.002?second Universe Slice along the timeline? Where am I supposed to find my own manual?”

“Don’t you have any after-sales service? Your civilization made it all the way to the End of Time, and you didn’t even leave a user guide? Hello? Hey—”

“Is anyone here?”

No one. He was the only one in the darkness.

In the long emptiness after his home universe was torn apart by the Great Annihilation, the last and only mind kept running, dazed, inside this hard black “cocoon.” The only difference from all those long past years was that this mind had, for the first time, realized how vast the void around “itself” really was.

He did not know how much time had passed. Zhou Ming felt he might have been standing here in this darkness for a whole century for no real reason before he finally let out a soft sigh.

“There really is nothing here…”

He muttered in a self-mocking way. Then he sat down right where he was in the dark, planning to rest a bit—even though this impossible body, filled with starlight, did not seem to feel tired at all.

Just then, right as he was about to sit, Zhou Ming caught something at the edge of his vision—he saw a very thin, almost invisible “bright edge” drift past the border of his sight, flashing once in the darkness.

His eyes opened a little wider.

It was a thin thread.

In the next second, he grabbed the thread without any hesitation. The faint resistance in his hand told him the thread was really there… it was not an illusion!

Zhou Ming quickly raised his hand and held the thread up in front of his eyes, examining it closely. After a while, he began to search for the source of the thread.

The thread came from beyond that unseen barrier… from outside the “cocoon.”

Zhou Ming slowly stood up, gripping the thread tightly in his hand. He saw that this line, almost invisible to the naked eye, passed through the “invisible barrier” he could never break, drifting lightly in the endless darkness outside. The other end of the thread vanished into the void. He could not see where it led or what it was tied to.

Zhou Ming pulled the thread toward himself a few times. It felt as if there would never be an end to it. The faint, steady resistance from the other side stopped him from pulling harder. He was afraid of snapping this single “connection” to the outside.

After some more time, after more hesitation and thought, he finally made up his mind. He slowly raised a finger and summoned a tiny ball of ghostly green flame, then carefully brought the little flame close to the thread.

Almost in the blink of an eye, the small flame seemed to be pulled by some invisible force and rushed entirely into the depth of the thread.

Then his connection with the flame cut off.

Zhou Ming blinked. This had never happened before, and for a moment he was a bit stunned.

His link with the flame had broken! It was completely, totally, absolutely gone!

Before today, even when it was separated from him by a whole dimension in the Abyssal Deep, his link with the flame had never been fully cut!

Was it a problem with the thread? Or was it the invisible barrier blocking it?

Zhou Ming could not help but think it over, but after only a few seconds, he suddenly felt his hand go empty—the thin thread had vanished.

Before he could react, a low hum rose from all directions. Right after that, all light and color rushed back into his eyes. It was as if all the units of a system that had shut down for a moment were coming back online. With a burst of dizzying light and shadow, the walls, windows, ceiling, floor, and all the furniture of the room reappeared with a roar!

The sudden change left Zhou Ming a bit dazed. He stepped back two steps on reflex and grabbed the shelf beside him for support—the branches of Atlantis drooped down and brushed against his arm.

“Not even a little warning… this is still my ‘home’…”

Zhou Ming could not help grumbling. Shaking his head, he looked around to check the room. Then he seemed to sense something and suddenly raised his head to look into the distance.

Almost the instant he looked up, a sound rang out and echoed through the quiet apartment—

“Dong, dong, dong…”

Someone was knocking on the door.

Chapter 739: A Figure Before Doomsday

No words could describe the shock that hit Zhou Ming at that moment.

The knocking sound—dong, dong, dong—was not loud. In normal times, it would have been the most ordinary noise. But when it echoed in this tiny apartment, every knock felt like a world-shaking roar, like a hammer slamming into Zhou Ming’s ears!

His eyes flew wide. For an instant he almost thought this was some illusion born from the chain of events and disappointments he had just gone through. But he quickly sobered and realized the knocking was a real sound—and it was still going on.

He rushed to the door like a gust of wind and grabbed the handle. But just as he was about to turn it, he suddenly hesitated for two seconds.

Could he really just open the door? Would he be rushing straight into a trap?

If this had been back in the first days of being trapped in this room, he would not have had such worries. At that time he only thought the thick fog was some strange “phenomenon,” and he was sure his familiar home still lay beyond it. But now, Zhou Ming already knew what had happened to his world—his homeland had long since turned to ashes. The only thing left in the entire universe was this one small room, and deep within that endless fog… there was nothing but the ash left after Universal Extinction.

After the world had died, who would still come and knock on his door?

No matter how he thought about it, it was almost impossible for it to be a normal “living person.”

Zhou Ming weighed his choices carefully, while the knocking still repeated patiently. Each round of three dull knocks came every three to five seconds. It did not sound urgent, but it fully showed the knocker’s patience and stubbornness. It was like a polite yet stubborn Visitor, set on paying a call.

…If he opened the door, it might be a trap. But if he did not open it, he might miss this “visit.” Whoever stood outside, this was a once?in?forever event. He had to find out what it was.

Countless thoughts flashed through Zhou Ming’s mind. In the end, he took a small breath and quietly made up his mind. One hand stayed on the handle, and with the other he lightly brushed the doorframe.

Translucent phantom flames flowed and spread along the frame, forming a hazy burning barrier.

After he finished his precautions and raised his guard as high as it could go, he tightened his grip and suddenly twisted the handle, yanking the door open at great speed.

There was no one outside the door. There was only the same swirling, pulsing, writhing black fog as always.

Zhou Ming was breathing heavily. His heart pounded. He stared wide?eyed at the empty fog for a long time, unable to react.

Had he still opened the door too late? Had the knocking Visitor lost patience? Was it really such a coincidence that the Visitor left at the exact moment he opened the door?

Zhou Ming frowned. He was sure the knocking had continued right up until he opened the door. Even if the one outside had lost patience, they should not have pulled away in an instant.

He hesitated, and then a sound suddenly broke his thoughts.

It was the knocking again—the dong, dong, dong of a fist on a door reached his ears once more.

Zhou Ming's eyes widened. He stared hard at the swirling fog in front of him. At last, he noticed it—the knocking sound was actually coming from within the black fog.

The sound seemed very close, almost pressed right against the surface of the fog, close enough to touch with a hand. But no matter how wide Zhou Ming opened his eyes, he could not see anything inside the fog. When he reached his hand into the thick mist, he felt only cold emptiness—there was nothing in there.

Only the knocking kept repeating, still as patient as ever.

Zhou Ming slowly drew back the hand he had stretched into the fog. He stood quietly in the doorway, listening to that knocking that seemed like it would never stop, calming the storm in his head.

There was a Visitor on the far side of the fog, trying to open this "little house," but they were blocked by the shell of the "cocoon."

After he stood in silent thought for a long time, Zhou Ming suddenly raised his head as something came to him. He turned and ran quickly to the desk.

He hurriedly gathered up a few things—a whiteboard marker, paper, a roll of soft measuring tape, a ball of string, and many other little odds and ends. He stuffed them all into a plastic bag, then carried it back to the doorway.

Then he found a small slip of paper and quickly wrote a line on it in the common tongue of the Boundless Sea: “I heard you. Who are you?”

He stuck the note to the mouth of the plastic bag, then, without any hesitation, threw the bag toward the swirling black fog.

The plastic bag stuffed with junk was swallowed by the writhing mist in an instant and vanished into the depths of the darkness.

Zhou Ming stared wide?eyed in the direction where the bag had disappeared. Even his breathing unconsciously slowed. He had never waited this nervously for “something” to happen. Not even when the great fire in Pland broke out had he been this tense.

The knocking stopped. In the very second after the bag of items passed through the fog, the dong, dong, dong came to an abrupt halt.

Clearly, the “Visitor” on the far side of the fog had received the “gift” he sent and reacted to it—but after that, no matter how long Zhou Ming waited, there was no further response.

Aside from the knocking coming to an end, no more information arrived.

Until, somewhere else—

On the chart table, Goathead suddenly sensed something. Its wooden neck creaked as it turned toward the door of the captain’s cabin—a tall, imposing figure opened the door and walked in, his steps heavy.

“Name?”

“Duncan Abnomar.”

Duncan slowly walked behind the enchanted sea chart table and sat down in the chair with a backrest. He let out a long breath, as if he were pushing all his fatigue and tangled thoughts out of his body with that single sigh.

Goathead instantly noticed the captain’s state. It had already prepared an aria of at least five minutes to greet the captain and chat about the border’s unique weather, but now it swallowed all of that in one gulp. After hesitating for a moment, it carefully asked: “Are you… all right? You look upset.”

Duncan glanced at Goathead and said casually: “Someone knocked and got stood up.”

Goathead thought this over very seriously: “…Does this have something to do with AI?”

Duncan waved his hand, already long used to this kind of completely off? topic question.

“Looks like it has nothing to do with AI,” Goathead said at once, even more used to this than Duncan was. Once it realized the captain did not want to say more, it quickly adjusted its mood and changed the subject: “We’re about to pass through the thick fog of the Eternal Veil, Captain. Are we heading straight back to Lightwind Harbor next, or do you have other plans?”

“…We’ll head back to Lightwind Harbor. I need some time to sort out my thoughts, and I also need to discuss a few things with those Popes—they should all be staying in the city?state for now.”

“Understood, Captain,” Goathead answered at once. Then it opened its mouth again, clearly hesitated, and went on: “Also, what do you think about what Vanna and Morris reported?”

“You mean those ‘figures’ they saw before they evacuated Sacred Island?”

“Yes,” Goathead said. “Wearing ragged robes, looking like phantoms of a Ender, but they never interacted with anyone, as if they existed in another space?time entirely… This doesn’t sound like the Enders we know. They

appeared on Sacred Island, and… I just feel like there’s something very strange about this.”

Duncan thought for a moment. Then he casually took out a palm?sized photo print and laid it on the enchanted sea chart table to study it carefully.

It was what Morris had given him during their earlier meeting in the cabin —the only piece of evidence the Old Scholar had managed to gather when he witnessed those suspicious figures suddenly appear on Sacred Island.

The image on the photo was not very clear. Fine stripes covered the whole picture like some kind of interference or gauze veil. Even so, one could still make out the black door deep inside the cavern, and the vague white figure by the door.

The white figure in the tattered robe had features blurred into a smear. Only from his posture and position could one tell he seemed to be carefully observing something—observing the black door, or something behind it.

“In the past, when a Ender appeared before people, they were either lunatics who had lost their reason and knew only how to wildly spread their Doomsday theories, or they were still?sane Scholars trying to pass on information or give some mental guidance to the witnesses,” Goathead muttered at Duncan’s side. “This is the first time we’ve seen phantoms that don’t interact with anyone at all. They all looked busy with their own work and didn’t notice the intense fighting nearby at all, like…”

Duncan spoke softly: “Like travelers in a hurry, making their way along a journey.”

Goathead froze for a second: “You mean…”

“Just a sudden thought,” Duncan said, raising his head. “They looked absorbed in their work and didn’t react to their surroundings at all. Maybe… what we saw was the End Survey Team, moving through the

Time?Stream to make their observations. This is what they look like when they're 'on the road.'"

Goathead's wooden jaw moved: "…So you're saying Vanna and Morris saw the afterimages those Critt people left while traveling through the Time? Stream? But there have never been any records of sightings like that before…"

"Maybe it's related to the special environment at the border. Or maybe…"

Duncan stopped. After a brief silence, he shook his head.

"Or maybe it's another prophetic vision."

For a moment, Goathead did not react: "Another prophetic vision?"

"Back when the End Survey Team set out from the early era of the Deep Sea, they reached as far as 'the end of time,' which is the moment of the Sanctuary World's End," Duncan said calmly. His gaze, almost divine, rested on Goathead's eyes. "That means…"

He did not finish the sentence, but Goathead already understood: "That means we'll see them at the end of time. Doomsday is the only moment when our Time?Stream and theirs truly meet…"

Duncan did not answer. He only quietly watched the photo on the enchanted sea chart table, watching that hazy figure standing by the black door, as if carefully observing something.

He did not know if it was just his imagination, but he felt that the blurry figure had grown a little clearer.

Chapter 740: The Long Sunset

The grand wall of mist, like a giant barrier reaching to the sky, showed faint ripples on its surface. The cloud streams pouring down from the top of the mist wall were briefly lit by a burst of fire from within—then a gush of pale green flame erupted out, and the towering bow of the Vanished broke through the wall of fog, dragging thin shreds of mist as it sailed toward the “normal sea” ahead.

Right behind the Vanished, the Radiant Star, the Tide, the Rest, and the other warships and escort vessels of all sizes also pushed out of the thick fog.

As the wall of mist slowly drew away behind the stern, the dim, muddled glow in the sky faded. In its place came normal sunlight. The setting sun was slowly sinking toward the distant horizon, and the double rune rings at the edge of Vision 001 were already touching the sea. Golden-red light flooded across the world, vast and magnificent, yet carrying a faint sense of wrongness.

The seafarers who had returned safely from the fog all let out a breath. Strictly speaking, the fleet was still in the border sea, but just seeing sunlight again and the rolling blue ocean was enough to make them feel at ease, and feel the warmth that belonged to the “orderly world.”

“We have already made contact with the Cathedral ark in Lightwind Harbor,” Vanna came to the bow and found the captain, who was standing on the deck and looking into the distance. “I gave a brief report on what

happened on Sanctuary Island. Your Eminence Helena is looking forward to seeing you again."

"Mm." Duncan answered simply, but he seemed a little distracted. After a moment, he pulled his gaze back from the distant sea and looked at Vanna. "Is there something else?"

"We are a bit worried," Vanna said. She hesitated for a second, then spoke in a serious tone. "You have seemed even more preoccupied since you left the captain's cabin. Did something happen?"

"I just discussed some troubling things with Goathead," Duncan let out a slow breath. "It has to do with the two suspicious phantoms you and Morris saw."

Vanna blinked: "The two phantoms we saw?"

"Yes, they…" Duncan nodded. He was just about to explain it to Vanna when a sudden sound cut him off.

It was a low, deep hum, like a giant reed plate being struck hard somewhere deep in the clouds. The hum was distant and long, as if it echoed through the whole sky.

Vanna clearly heard it too. She jumped in surprise and lifted her head toward the source of the sound, staring at the distant clouds. Almost at the same time, Morris and Lucretia ran out from a nearby cabin, looking up at the sky in shock.

Many other sailors in the fleet also heard the strange hum. On the three main Church warships, priests and guardian warriors, alarmed by the noise, rushed onto the decks and looked up in confusion at the sky where the echo still lingered. Some of them pointed toward the distant clouds, as if they had noticed something wrong hidden in their depths.

Duncan narrowed his eyes. His sight was drawn by a faint glow behind the clouds, and he could not help looking toward that direction. In the next second, that glow brightened in his vision.

It traced a clear path as it moved behind the clouds, slow on the surface yet truly fast.

Not far away, Lucretia's eyes suddenly widened.

With a series of low rumbles that grew clearer and stronger, the moving glow behind the clouds swelled quickly. Brilliant golden light flashed through gaps in the cloud layer. Moments later, the glowing mass broke through the northwestern clouds—a splendid glowing orb, falling along an arc toward the northern sea.

Like a small Sun Wheel dropping from the heavens, the huge shining body grew smaller and smaller, finally sinking into the far-off waters.

After a brief moment of shock, Duncan reacted at once. He whipped his head around to look at Lucretia, and saw that Lucretia was also looking up at him.

Duncan did not speak, but the Sea Witch already knew what Father wanted to ask. She nodded slightly, her face grave.

The second glowing orb had fallen.

On the nearby Tide, sailors cried out in alarm. Some who reacted quickly looked up at the Sun, and among those with sharp eyes… someone had already noticed the new second gap that had appeared in the rune rings.

Lucretia walked over quickly. Before Duncan could ask, she spoke first: "By eye, it fell toward the north. It should be near Frost Sea—I don't know if my brother noticed it…"

“I did see a flash of gold from the cemetery over there, but the buildings in the city blocked my view,” Duncan said at once. Then he focused his mind and called to the distant northern mark: “Tyrian.”

A wave of clear confusion rushed back along the mark. Then Duncan heard the answer from the “Steel Vice Admiral” in his mind: “I’m here, Father.”

Along with his reply came a jumble of background noise. It sounded a little chaotic around Tyrian.

“Did you see a huge glowing fallen relic?” Duncan asked right away, while he also noticed the confusion on that side. “What is going on over there? Why is it such a mess?”

Tyrian’s voice came through in broken pieces: “Things are a bit… complicated here… I did see the glowing fallen relic you mentioned…”

“Where did it roughly fall?” Lucretia cut in directly. “How far from the city-state? Is it inside the civilized world’s borders?”

Tyrian went quiet for a few seconds. Then his answer came in a hollow tone: “…It hit me on the head.”

Duncan and Lucretia: “…?”

“Strictly speaking, it hit the Frostholm coast,” Tyrian added at once. “But the glowing orb of this thing is huge. Part of its glowing structure stretches right into the city. My office is inside the coverage area… it’s a bit chaotic here right now… this thing is really bright, and it came so suddenly, my eyes are having trouble adapting…”

Duncan and Lucretia again: “…”

To be honest, Duncan had not seen that coming at all…

The awkward silence lasted a moment. At last, Duncan coughed twice: “Has anyone been hurt?”

“We can’t be sure yet. There shouldn’t be any direct injuries, because the glowing part of that thing is non?material. When it fell, it did not even stir a speck of dust. Its physical part landed off the coast, and there were no ships sailing there,” Tyrian said. The chaos on his side seemed to ease a little as he spoke and issued orders in the background. “But the fall of the glowing orb was so sudden that it has already caused panic in the city. I am sending people to calm the affected districts and check for any damage…”

Tyrian paused for a moment. Then he spoke again: “Lucy, this thing should be…”

“It should be the same kind of thing as the glowing geometric body here at Lightwind Harbor. The rune rings on the edge of the Sun now have a second gap that you can see with the naked eye, and it’s even bigger than last time,” Lucretia said, her tone heavy. “The Sun’s disintegration may be speeding up.”

“…Damn.”

“I will send you all my research data on the glowing geometric body as soon as I can,” Lucretia said. “You need to set up a matching research facility. At the very least, move that fallen relic to a safe sea area near the city-state. There should be a solid core at its center… Once things settle down on your side, send someone to find that core and tell me what state it is in.”

“I understand.”

After they exchanged a few more details, Duncan ended the contact with Tyrian.

The deck fell quiet for a time. Bathed in the golden-red glow of the sunset, Duncan and Lucretia stood side by side, both silent.

An invisible weight pressed down on Lucretia’s chest, like some unseen countdown timer. It made her feel short of breath.

She lifted her head and looked at Father. She moved her lips: “Dad…”

Another strange hum came from the sky and cut off what she had been about to say.

The golden-red evening glow vanished at once. Murky darkness washed over everything in sight in a single instant.

The Sun went out again.

From Pland to Frostholm, from Lightwind Harbor to the fleet in the border sea—before the eyes of countless people, the Sun once more fell into darkness. With it came that odd, low hum. The sphere at the center of Vision 001 turned into a terrifying black hollow, leaving only the golden double rune rings fixed on the sea’s horizon, barely lighting the dim, muddled sky.

The two gaps in the rune rings now looked even more obvious, even more shocking.

“The Observer Effect stabilizing anchor has shut down again…”

Alice walked out from the cabin, staring in a daze at the distant, darkened Sun.

“How long will it stay off this time?” Nina came up beside her and muttered uneasily.

“I don’t know,” Alice shook her head. “The system is still showing errors. It’s trying to reboot.”

Dog and Shirley came out as well. Dog squatted on the deck in silence, staring at the horizon. Shirley cast a careful glance at the captain not far

away, then muttered under her breath: “…the Sun will light up again, right? It’s not going to stay dark this time, is it…”

“It can’t be that bad, can it?” Nina was startled by Shirley’s words. Then she thought for a moment and sounded less sure. “If it really stayed dark… should I think about hanging up in the sky all the time and lighting the city-state myself… But I wouldn’t be able to light up much on my own, and I wouldn’t get any weekends off, would I?”

Shirley had been half worried and half sighing over the situation, but when she heard her friend mumbling, her expression turned odd. She glanced sideways at Nina: “…Don’t you think that idea is a bit much?”

“Things are already pretty ‘a bit much’ right now…”

Shirley and Nina bickered back and forth, each line taking them farther off topic. It seemed they were trying to ease their nervousness by chatting. While they talked, that low, weird humming sound suddenly echoed in the sky once again.

Almost without giving anyone time to react, the world that had been dark for only a few minutes lit up under sunlight again—the Sun restarted, and the golden-red sunset shone over the sea as if it had never gone out.

Shirley and Nina stared at each other.

This time, the Sun’s “reboot” was clearly faster than the last two times.

“It’s bright again!” After a short daze, Shirley finally reacted and shouted in delight: “It only went out for a few minutes this time!”

“That scared me. I thought it was going to be like before and stay dark for more than ten hours…” Nina also let out a breath. “Looks like things aren’t that bad.”

Not far away, Morris also seemed to relax. A faint smile appeared on his face.

Compared to the last two times, the Sun had stayed out for a much shorter period this time. Whatever the reason it could restart so quickly… the return of sunlight was, in the end, a good thing.

On the Vanished, on the Tide, and on the other Church warships, people also relaxed in the renewed sunlight. The light eased the nerves that had just tensed up.

But an hour later, something felt wrong.

The Sun was still in the same place.

Two hours later, the long dusk still had not ended.

Chapter 741: The Long Night Begins

Hurried footsteps broke the calm inside the sanctuary. A middle?aged priest in a deep blue robe stitched with gold hurried down a long corridor like a gust of wind. Under the silent gazes of the many sages painted on the walls, he came to the door of the prayer room—but before he could knock, a gentle female voice sounded from within: “Come in.”

The middle?aged priest pushed open the door and saw the figure standing before the statue of the Storm Goddess. Helena wore a simple priest’s gown. A string of sea?blue crystals coiled around her wrist, and it seemed she had been offering a devout benediction just a second ago. She did not turn when she heard the door open behind her. She only kept gazing quietly at the veiled face of the Goddess’s statue and spoke softly: “How are things outside?”

“dusk is still ongoing. The Sun is still in its previous position and keeps a ‘normal’ brightness and form,” the middle?aged priest lowered his head and reported at once. “Order in the city-state is still good. Since the situation is unclear, most citizens have gone back home to wait for further instructions. Everything on the ark is normal as well. There are no anomalies. Four teams of technical Fathers are already on standby near the steam boilers.”

Helena nodded slightly, as if thinking quietly. After a moment, she suddenly asked: “What about the other arks?”

“We just made contact a few minutes ago. Everything is normal on the other arks. The Academy Ark says their instruments have received a series of repeated signals from the direction of the Sun. The content of those signals is different from before. When converted into sound, they become sharp, short bursts of noise…”

Helena gave a soft “mm” and fell silent again. She went on staring at the statue of the Goddess, as if she had forgotten the priest still standing beside her, waiting for orders. Only after a few minutes did she speak again, as if to herself: “A long dusk…”

Taran Ael frowned as he studied the data his apprentice had just brought him. Long paper strips fed from the machine were covered in complex lines and a mess of holes that would leave any ordinary person dizzy. Yet all this “gibberish” described the state of “Vision 001 – the Sun,” which had shone on and sheltered this world for so long.

After a long time, the elven scholar finally set the paper strip down and rubbed his temples, too tired to speak.

A calm voice sounded from the side: “Tell me what we are dealing with, Taran.”

Taran Ael lifted his head and saw Ted Riel, who stood beside a bookshelf. The Truth Keeper wore an academy robe, but underneath it Taran could see close?fitting mail and weapon fittings. He stood there with a calm look, yet his eyes were as sharp as a soldier about to step onto a battlefield.

“…the Sun is flickering,” Taran Ael said at last. “You can’t tell with the naked eye, but it is flickering. And it’s not any kind of regular ‘signal.’ It’s more like… an electric lamp in bad condition.” He pressed his dry lips together and pushed the data aside. “Also, the latest tracking records show that it is not fully fixed on the horizon. It is still moving, only… very, very slowly. So slow that no one can see it move.”

Ted Riel was silent for two or three seconds: “…How slow?”

“If its current speed does not change, it will drop below the horizon in about seventy?two hours,” Taran Ael said. He reached for his cup and almost knocked it over. He grabbed it in a rush and took two heavy gulps of cold tea. Only then did his face look a little better. “But the worst part is not the seventy?two hours of dusk coming next. It is what comes after dusk, Ted. You know what I mean.”

“…Night will last longer than dusk,” Ted Riel said, his expression turning serious at once. Of course he understood his friend’s meaning. “If it keeps moving at this speed, how long will the night last?”

Taran Ael did not answer. He only set the cup down and stared at the pages on his desk, as if he was trying to see the future of this world inside those sheets, as if he wanted to dig out some enemy’s secret from them. A long time later, he let out a bitter smile and spread his hands at Ted.

“…I will have the Knowledge Guards get ready,” Ted Riel said quietly after watching his friend for a while. He nodded lightly. “We have plans for long?term missions in case we suddenly fall into a lasting ‘After the Darkness’ again. The glowing fallen relic near Lightwind Harbor will also provide basic shelter during the veil of night. Things will not be too bad.”

“Yes. Lightwind Harbor will not be too bad—the other city?states might not be so lucky.” After a brief silence, Taran Ael sighed softly. “Unlike the previous times the Sun went out and each city-state simply ‘skipped over time,’ this time we are facing the Sun slowing down. Every city-state is going through this world?level Vision together… I don’t know how they will face the long veil of night to come.”

“Every city-state has survival plans for extreme cases, but how much they can really do is another matter… All we can do is hope, and pray that the Four Gods protect them.”

Ted Riel’s voice was low and heavy. Then he shook his head and picked up the thick book in his hand, which recorded many sacred miracles. He seemed ready to open a passage and leave, but suddenly hesitated. He put the book away again, sighed, and walked toward the door.

Taran watched the Truth Keeper’s back, just as if he were watching a warrior about to step onto the battlefield. Only after Ted’s figure disappeared beyond the door did he pull his gaze back and glance at the data he had just pushed aside.

At the bottom of one page, shaky handwriting had left a line of notes from the observers—

“…By current calculations… time until the end of sunset… seventy?two hours…”

Outside the tall window beside him, golden sunset light still blanketed the layered roofs of the city-state, splendid and grand.

Then he heard faint, unreal bells.

The ringing was urgent and repeated in a fixed pattern, as if calling to everyone who heard it, calling them to come and listen to this proclamation before the veil of night descended—

Deep inside the great Cathedral of Pland, Archbishop Valentine had been discussing how to handle the Sun’s anomaly with Governor Dante Wayne when he suddenly stopped and tilted his head, listening to the sudden bell.

Across from him, the governor raised his head at once: “Your Excellency Bishop? What happened?”

Valentine waved his hand lightly. After a short pause, he answered: “It is the Swift Bell.”

“The Swift Bell?” The color shifted slightly on Dante’s face. He was not clergy of the Church, but because of his connection to Vanna he knew many things about the Church and thus knew what the “Swift Bell” was. “So…”

But Valentine shook his head: “No. Let us continue, Governor.”

“…You are not going to answer the Swift Bell’s summons?”

“I will not,” Valentine said slowly. For a moment, he seemed to remember many things, but in the end he still shook his head. “That is an order.”

Do not answer that bell.
Do not answer the tomb of the Nameless King.
Do not answer the call of that Gravekeeper—

The bell kept ringing, again and again, in every city-state, every Cathedral, every ship, and in the minds of every cleric who believed in the Four Gods. The urgent, repeated peals echoed without end.

priests all over froze for a heartbeat the moment the bell rang in their minds. Yet after that brief pause, they all went back to their busy work—continuing to receive and comfort the faithful who came seeking help, continuing to tend Holy Relics and maintain the Cathedrals, continuing to prepare blessings for the warriors who might soon face a very long veil of night.

The bell’s sound was like wind at the ear and waves in the far distance. It echoed out there somewhere, yet no priest answered its call anymore…

In that remote, other dimension, in the ancient gathering ground shrouded in dark chaos, the last group of Penitent Ascetics stationed there stood in silence, gazing toward the center of the square.

Tall stone pillars ringed the gathering ground. Chaotic streams of light slid across the dim sky. An old, pale pyramid?tomb rose from the middle of the plaza, and from its front walked the Gravekeeper, his whole body wrapped

in bandages, as if he existed forever on the border between life and death. He stepped out into the empty, abandoned meeting place.

But unlike the countless years before, there was no longer any Saint standing here. The Gravekeeper held pen and paper in his hands, yet no one came to hear news from the tomb.

The Penitent Ascetics stood far from the center, at a safe distance. Their bodies were covered in rune tattoos that marked the blessings of the Four Gods. Their eyes and ears were sealed by spells. They sensed the state of the tomb through God?granted sacred miracles, so they would not look directly at the Gravekeeper or hear his voice with their own senses.

The Gravekeeper walked a few steps out from the tomb. Vast shadows grew from behind him. Nameless limbs and twisted entities spread like thick, shifting sludge along his path. He came to stand before the ascetics and held out a sheet of parchment. On the parchment, trembling eyeballs kept surfacing and sinking. He opened his rotten, warped mouth and called out to the watchers.

His voice was like ten thousand curses of blasphemous corruption. Every vibration stabbed at the heart and tore at reason.

The Ascetic Watchers only stood there at the edge of the tomb’s range, statues in human form, silently “watching” over the tomb’s guard post.

They could not give any answer.
They could not speak with him.
But they also could not leave their station.

The formless, crawling shadows slowly calmed down. After a long face?off, the Gravekeeper lowered his head and stared at the parchment in his hands with his cloudy eyes. He stayed silent for a long time, then finally turned and walked back toward the tomb.

Low, layered whispers seeped out from within the tomb. The Gravekeeper’s muttering merged with the murmurs that came from inside.

He spoke in a low voice, repeating the same words again and again—

“dusk has come…”

Chapter 742: revelation

The Sun moved slowly, at a speed almost impossible for the naked eye to see, sinking very, very slowly toward the line of the sea. Brilliant golden-red light spilled over the Boundless Sea. This magnificent yet eerie, drawn-out dusk still did not end.

For the first time in history, dusk had become something terrifying. More and more people had realized that once this slow sunset finally ended, what waited afterward would be even more frightening: the veil of night, whose end no one could predict.

Dante Wayne stood on the terrace outside his City Hall office, frowning as he looked at the streets washed in afterglow. The close-packed rooftops of Pland's Upper City shone with a dizzying brilliance in the setting sun. This familiar view had once been his pride as Governor, but as the sunset dragged on and on, that pride slowly turned into a heavy pressure.

But he knew that compared with other "ordinary" and "normal" city-states, Pland was already in very good shape.

The flames left behind by the "ghost captain" gave this city the safest veil of night on the Boundless Sea. Even after the Sun set, there should not be any large-scale supernatural incursions here. The Long Night would bring the city heavy pressure, but at least it would not involve those Inhuman Things growing in the dark. All he had to worry about was law and order under the Long Night, the lives of the residents, stockpiled supplies, and things like adjusting production.

Elsewhere, things were not so simple.

In northern Cold Harbor, the city government had already declared a state of emergency. Constable units and Guardian units hurried through streets and alleys repairing Sanctuary Worlds and stockpiling Holy Oil. In Morka, the Truth Academy had activated every Steam Walker stored in the Cathedral arsenal and stationed them at gasworks, pump rooms, and steam hubs across the city. In the southwestern seas, several city-states had announced new “veil of night bans.” Residents in outer districts were to be moved temporarily to the nearest Cathedral shelter, inner districts would be sealed off, and huge bonfires would be lit the moment the Sun dropped and would burn until this night ended…

All stockpiled materials were being counted and moved. In the seventy-two hours before the Sun went down, every city-state was gathering its strength to face the coming veil of night.

If it could end at all.

Footsteps sounded behind him. A young official from the government office came into the room. Through the open sliding door, he saw Dante Wayne on the terrace. He coughed lightly twice and said: “Governor, the people in charge of the steam hubs, power plants, and mining facilities are already waiting for you in the conference room. Would you like to…”

Dante nodded and waved his hand lightly: “I know. Go on ahead. Wait for me a few minutes.”

The footsteps left the room. Dante let out a quiet breath. As he loosened his tense expression, he also tried to sort out his thoughts.

He turned around, walked past his wide curved desk, and reached for a file.

His gaze stopped on a photo frame at the edge of the desk.

In the frame, two figures stood side by side. One was his younger self. Beside him stood a tall, silver-haired maiden with a faint smile on her face. They stood beside a flowerbed, with bright sunlight falling behind them.

This was the only photo of Dante Wayne, already buried in work, and Vanna, who had entered a Church school early for training. After this photo, they never seemed to have such a carefree afternoon again.

“I wonder how things are going for Vanna…”

A few memories surfaced. Dante missed the warm sunlight that had faded into memory. Then he looked past the frame and found the file he needed. He tucked it under his arm and hurried toward the office door.

Vanna woke with a start from a chain of messy, shattered, bizarre dreams. Soft sounds of waves still echoed around her. Outside the porthole, the crash of breaking waves against the hull rose and fell, easing her unsettled mood.

She no longer remembered what had happened in the dream. She only remembered that the suddenly twisting, tearing things had cast some kind of indelible shadows in her eyes. The memories of the dream faded, but a lonely, desolate, ruined “atmosphere” seemed to have long shrouded her mind. Even now it still felt faintly cold.

Vanna sat up on the bunk and looked toward the window not far away. The glow of the setting sun still spread across the sea. She did not know when the Vanished had left its Spirit Realm state, but now it was sailing on the sea in the Mortal Realm. In the distance she could see the silhouette of the Radiant Star. That oddly shaped Magic warship was cutting through the waves at full speed alongside the Vanished.

As for the Tide, the Rest, and the other Church warships, they had already left. After the fleet passed beyond the border Veil, the Vanished and the

Radiant Star had parted ways with the Church ships, each going on to deal with its own matters.

Vanna let out a soft breath, then took several deep breaths. The slightly salty air drifted into her nose, and the soft, layered sound of the waves still echoed in her mind.

She suddenly frowned, as if sensing something, and quickly turned to look at a corner of the room.

Gentle seawater rose inside the cabin. She did not know when it had already surrounded her on all sides. Illusory waves sounded at her ears. At the moment Vanna turned her head, that gently rising seawater seemed to expand countless times at once, and the whole room expanded with it.

At the far end of the room, which had suddenly become hard to tell real from unreal, Vanna saw a vast shadow. Some huge… biological structure floated at the end of the slowly rolling waves.

A part of that living structure stretched toward her and condensed a figure above the sea surface: a woman in a long dress black as the abyssal sea, her true face hidden by a veil.

Her divine gaze rested on Vanna. In the pair of eyes with strange diamond-shaped pupils seemed to surge countless thoughts and feelings that could not be directly expressed. Under that gaze, Vanna suddenly felt a nameless sense of closeness and… a stirring deep inside.

She reacted at once. Her whole body went tense as she bowed her head deeply: “My Lord…”

“We do not have much time, child,” the figure said softly. With her words came layered noise strong enough to tear an ordinary person’s mind apart and throw them into a runaway state. Her thoughts echoed directly in

Vanna's mind. "…Our link with the mortal world will strengthen one last time…"

An irresistible dizziness rose from deep inside her. Vanna instantly realized she was being corrupted—corrupted by the very goddess she worshipped with all her heart. The goddess's voice, her thoughts, and the vision she was sending were all filled with a chaos unlike anything Vanna had ever felt before.

But Vanna still forced her mind to steady. At the edge of her vision, she saw a wisp of gentle, ghostly green flame rising and burning, pulling her thoughts back into balance.

"…What do you need me to do?" She tried not to look straight at the vast shadow behind the Storm Goddess. Fighting to stay conscious, she spoke again: "What can I do?"

"…Gather those fallen stars… let them protect you once more… go and tell the Flame Usurper that we wish to… talk with him… we will find…"

The layered sound of the waves slowly turned into some kind of unbearable, piercing shriek. The gentle rising seawater seemed to grow foul. A deep cold seeped into her bones and slowly drowned her whole body. Vanna barely picked out the last words from the noise echoing in her ears. Her head felt as if it would split, and she had no strength left to think about what those words meant. In her blurring vision, she saw the distant waters and the huge shadow silently collapse.

"You saw Gamona's revelation?" Duncan's eyes widened slightly. He looked at Vanna, who had suddenly rushed into the captain's cabin. Then he noticed how bad she looked. He stood at once and took her by the arm: "Sit here first. Catch your breath and talk slowly."

“Thank you… Captain.” Vanna was almost forced down into the chair by Duncan. The lingering stabbing pain and dizziness in her head made even thinking hard, but after seeing the captain, that state quickly eased, and her thoughts began to flow again. “I met her apparition directly and heard her voice… the goddess is in very bad shape. Those noises… they felt like facing those dark Outer Gods head-on.”

She took a few breaths and then told him everything she had just gone through.

After listening to Vanna’s report, Duncan frowned at once, and his expression slowly grew heavy.

“Go collect those fallen stars…” he muttered softly. As he spoke, he could not help recalling the “advice” he had once heard from a tentacle extended from the Abyssal Lord in the depths of the courtyard at Alice’s manor—

“Keep the fragments of the fallen ?#&**. When everything becomes impossible to save, use them to extend the life of each Node city as much as you can. Stay alive. Survival is the First Directive.”

Clearly, Vanna soon thought of the same thing.

“…Does the goddess mean those glowing fragments of glowing orb that broke off from the Sun’s rune ring belt?” She lifted her head and looked into Duncan’s eyes. “She means those glowing orbs can protect the city-states in the days ahead?”

“From our experience in Lightwind Harbor, the power of those glowing orbs is weaker than the Sun itself, but within a certain range they can still shield the World’s Wound and calm the veil of night,” Duncan said, nodding slowly. “Now the second fragment of glowing orb has fallen at Frostholm, and with the revelation you just received, it’s not hard to connect the dots.”

As he spoke, he looked up toward the window.

The slowly sinking Sun still hung above the distant sea. The broken rune rings cast magnificent patterns of light and shadow on the waves.

The revelation Gamona had given Vanna was not hard to understand. What truly bothered him was another meaning behind that revelation.

“…This is only the beginning,” he said softly. “It looks like the Sun’s disintegration is going to speed up. The real large-scale collapse and fall… is still to come.”

—

Chapter 743: Another Core

Vanna left. Even with her divine blessing, she still needed proper rest now.

Duncan watched her leave the captain's cabin. Only when she disappeared beyond the door did he look away and turn to Goathead, who was sitting quietly at the edge of the chart table: "What do you think of the 'revelation' Gamona sent to Vanna?"

"…A large-scale collapse and breakup of the Sun seems to be something the Four Gods knew would happen sooner or later," Goathead said, after holding himself back for a long time and finally seizing a chance to speak. "I knew they knew about it. They must have been bottling it up for ten thousand years! Back when the Abyssal Lord launched the Genesis Protocol, he talked it over with them as well, but after the Deep Sea era began, every time anyone asked, they all kept their mouths shut and never said what the problem really was. Of course, I can understand them. If they had said it out loud, the people scared to death would have been more than just one or two city-states. Even those popes were kept in the dark. And now look, the Sun is just straight-up starting to fall apart…"

Duncan looked up at him, then reached out and pressed a hand over Goathead's rambling mouth. "I shouldn't have asked you."

With his mouth covered, Goathead let out a string of muffled grunts. His obsidian-carved eyes rolled wildly on his wooden face, his gaze lively for the first time.

Duncan sighed and drew his hand back. “I was asking about the second half of the revelation… ‘They’ want to talk with me. What do you think they plan to talk about? And in what form?”

“…That I don’t know,” Goathead said this time with a rare bit of restraint, shaking his head in annoyance. “Maybe they’re going to coax you into taking over something again?”

Duncan did not answer. He simply sank into thought for a long moment.

The state “they” were in really did not seem good. Before this, Gamona had still been able to pass him a few broken words, but now she could only send down a revelation through Vanna, and it came with that much corruption…

Just then, a voice from far away suddenly broke his thoughts.

His eyes changed slightly. He looked up at the oval mirror hanging on the nearby wall. Under his divine gaze, a layer of phantom flame spread over it. The surface of the mirror turned pitch black, and then light and shadow slowly appeared.

Tyrian’s image appeared in the mirror.

“Father.” The “steel Vice Admiral” looked a little grim. The scene behind him seemed to be somewhere near the Harbor district, and a hazy golden glow soaked everything behind him. It was clearly not a normal sunset. “Sorry to disturb you so suddenly…”

“It’s fine.” Duncan waved a hand, his tone gentle. “What happened to make you so tense?”

“…Our scholar went inside the glowing geometric body that fell at Frostholm. Following the data Lucretia shared earlier, we did find its core. But that thing… isn’t quite the same as in the records. I hope you can see it with your own eyes.”

“Not quite the same?” Duncan frowned slightly. From Tyrian’s reaction, he sensed that things over there were complicated. He nodded at once. “I understand. I’ll be there soon.”

He quickly cut the link with Tyrian, focused his mind, and turned his head —

Outside the graveyard warden’s hut, fine snow fell without a sound. The evening sun sank, and the hazy snowy scene wrapped the whole world in silence.

Inside the warden’s hut, the stove crackled. The samovar whistled sharper and louder as the water came just to a boil and steam rose.

Duncan stood up and closed the stove’s vent a bit, then took the black brimmed hat hanging by the door. He put the hat on, straightened his long black coat, and stepped out of the hut.

Two young guards in black, who were sweeping the paths and checking the lamps in the graveyard, heard the sound and turned their heads at the same time. When they saw the silent warden, always wrapped in bandages and dressed in black from head to toe, walking out of the hut, they straightened at once and saluted.

Duncan waved back at them, then snapped his fingers. A skeletal roc wreathed in ghostly flame crossed a vast distance at once and landed on his shoulder.

“Full tank, let’s go!” Ai flapped her wings and, in her skeletal form, let out a harsh, grating cry. Then she suddenly turned into a violently rising ring of fire. The ring wrapped around Duncan, and the two of them merged into one. In an instant they shot into the sky, streaking toward the Harbor district…

In eastern Frostholm, a vast golden radiance still covered the whole Harbor. The light seemed to have a crystalline texture as it quietly soaked everything within its range. It was bright but not dazzling, gentle yet unsettling.

Aiden, tall and broad-shouldered with a shining bald head, stared nervously at the golden glow around them.

He had taken off the old gear he used to wear as a pirate and now wore the new uniform of Frostholm's modern navy. In front of his subordinates he always tried to look stern and reliable, but in front of Tyrian he did not hide his unease.

"Are these lights really harmless?" the big bald man muttered. "Looking at them, I feel like I'm being soaked in something. Feels like they're going to seep into my skin. Even when I breathe, it feels like something is pouring into my lungs…"

Tyrian turned his head and glanced at Aiden.

"First, your lungs already have at least seven holes in them. It's not like you pour anything good into those holes on a normal day," he said casually. "Second, we've confirmed these lights are harmless. In Lightwind Harbor, Lucretia has been studying this stuff for a long time."

"…But the thing that fell over here isn't the same as the one in Lightwind Harbor," Aiden muttered. "Their 'core' is a stone ball…"

This Undying commander, deeply trusted by Tyrian, shook his head. His polished head flashed with a bright golden streak in Tyrian's view.

Tyrian quietly sidestepped a little. He opened his mouth, about to say something, but then suddenly sensed a presence approaching and shut his mouth, turning his head.

At almost the same moment, a low, slightly hoarse voice reached both his and Aiden's ears: "You mean the core of this fallen relic isn't a 'stone sphere'?"

A pale green flame rose in silence, and Duncan stepped out of the fire. He walked past the startled guards and government staff around them and headed straight toward Tyrian and Aiden.

Aiden jumped in surprise but quickly recovered. He hurried forward two steps and bent down in salute. "Old Captain…"

A bright streak of gold swept across Duncan's vision. Without changing his expression, he stepped half a pace to the side to get away from the shine of Aiden's polished head.

"Father," Tyrian said, reacting as well and stepping forward. "I didn't expect you to arrive so fast."

"I'm very curious about the 'special situation' you mentioned," Duncan said, waving his hand as he walked forward. "Let's not waste time. Tell me on the way—what exactly is going on?"

Tyrian hurried to keep up, speaking quickly as they walked. "It's hard to describe to you. It's something we've never seen before… even the most learned scholars in the city-state are at a loss. It is a sphere, but its surface is unreal and always shifting, like some kind of living thing. It even makes a faint howling sound… you'll understand when you see it for yourself."

Listening to Tyrian's description, Duncan only nodded lightly and lengthened his stride.

They walked through the pale golden radiance that filled the entire Harbor district, crossed the docks and connecting bridges, and made their way to the shoreline. The way was very quiet. Everyone in the area had been evacuated in a hurry, and long lines of barricades cut the whole dock district

off from the city. The center of the glowing orb's glow lay right at one corner of this Harbor's coastline.

If someone looked down from the sky at that moment, they would see the irregular glowing geometric body covering almost one third of the city-state. It was as if a glowing structure had suddenly "grown" from the edge of Frostholm Island and was lighting up a vast area of sea around it in the dusk.

Led by Tyrian and Aiden, Duncan finally reached the center of the glowing geometric body and saw the "core structure" that had left Frostholm's scholars puzzled and even a little afraid.

It floated at the end of the beach, with calm seawater a dozen meters away. A sphere about ten meters across hung quietly there. Rough scaffolding already stood around its edges, and workers bustled nearby.

"See, that's it…" Tyrian raised his hand and pointed at the huge sphere. Its surface flowed with color and moved like a living thing, giving off a sense of unease. "This thing doesn't look like stone at all."

"…Of course it isn't stone…"

Duncan looked up, eyes half narrowed. After a brief moment of surprise, a strange feeling, both natural and hard to name, rose in his heart. He watched the "core," his lips moving a few times before he softly answered Tyrian's question.

"This is a gaseous planet."

Tyrian froze for a moment, then repeated the unfamiliar term in confusion: "A gaseous planet? What does that mean?"

Duncan did not answer. After watching it for a moment, he slowly walked two steps forward until he stood right under the floating "gaseous planet," quietly studying the structure of its surface.

Bands of brilliant clouds with a faint metallic sheen flowed slowly across its surface, drawing ring after ring of “cloud streams” around the whole body. Tiny vortices and storms spun between the cloud bands, slow and magnificent.

When he moved closer, he heard the “howling” Tyrian had mentioned. It was very faint, as if coming from a distant age.

The sound came from within the celestial body. Long, long ago, in the era before everything was wiped out, that howling might have been deafening and strong enough to tear apart a small celestial body. Back then, this planet had been vast and overwhelming, big enough to hold tens of thousands of Boundless Seas within its clouds.

But now, this “star” only ten meters across could give off only that faint, barely audible sound… like a sob.

Chapter 744

The second glowing geometric body that fell onto the Boundless Sea still had a Lost Star at its core, but its situation was different from the first fragment. This Lost Star was a compressed gas planet.

According to the scholars' initial measurements, the gas planet that served as the core still had a diameter of ten meters, exactly the same as the Moon inside the first fallen glowing orb.

Duncan cared more about something else: he did not recognize this planet.

At the very least, he was sure it was not a gas giant like Saturn or Jupiter that had once belonged to the Sun's system. The silver, gray, and bluish metallic tones on its surface, and the few very distinctive storm vortices, were all completely unfamiliar to him.

Duncan stood beside the compressed gas giant and studied the cloud bands and vortex patterns on its surface. Thoughts rose and fell in his mind.

The core of the first glowing geometric body had been the Moon from his home. So when this second fallen relic appeared, he had instinctively thought he would see another familiar body from the Sun's system. But now it seemed that the "raw material" used for the rune ring belt around the Sun was not limited to the Sun's system of his homeworld. The Lost Stars that formed that ring all came from far deeper space, and might even have come from different universes.

Celestial bodies from different worlds were compressed and twisted, then transformed into the halo around the Sun to keep the Observer Effect

stabilization anchor running. The Sun itself, as the core of it all, was in essence an eyeball sealed inside a crystalline shell. The eyeball stood for the eye of the observer. This whole device ensured that, after the Great Annihilation, incompatible World Wreckage could still collapse into a single Mortal Realm.

It seemed that this was the principle behind Vision 001.

After pondering for a long time, Duncan gently shook his head.

He knew that thinking about the workings of Vision 001 now was not very useful. This stabilization device, which had been running far past its service life, had already reached the end of its lifespan. Its collapse and extinction were fated. Even if he accepted Navigator One's "continuation plan", he could only use his own flame to replace Vision 001 and let this world enter an Age of Flame after the era of the Deep Sea. No matter what, the disintegration of the Observer Effect stabilization anchor itself was an irreversible process.

Even so, the way Vision 001 took effect still gave him some inspiration. After turning down Navigator One's plan, he had to find another way to carry the civilization of the Deep Sea era forward. He vaguely had an idea, and the principles behind Vision 001 would be very useful for refining that idea.

Tyrian and Aiden stood on the beach, a little tense and confused as they watched Duncan in the distance. They did not know what Father, the old captain, was doing, and they did not dare walk up and disturb him. But it was clear they had noticed how Duncan's expression shifted between deep thought and sudden insight.

Aiden looked around. After he made sure all unrelated people had already backed away, he moved closer to Tyrian, lowered his voice, and said: "What do you think the old captain is studying?"

“How would I know?” Tyrian lowered his voice as well. “I usually cannot understand what Lucy studies, let alone Father’s way of thinking. Maybe he is talking with that thing.”

Aiden thought for a moment, then nodded: “I think you are right.”

Duncan actually heard the quiet muttering from not far away, but he paid it no mind. After thinking for a moment, he suddenly spoke in his heart: “Alice.”

The doll’s voice answered almost at once: “Eh? Captain?”

“Come over for a bit. There is something I want you to see. Ai has already gone to pick you up.”

Alice paused for a second and then said: “Ah, then wait a bit for me. The potato cakes here are almost done. Do you want some? I can send a portion to your captain’s cabin.”

Duncan said: “No need. I am not hungry over here. Just come over as soon as you are done.”

Then he stood where he was and waited patiently. Several more minutes passed before a surge of ghostly green flame suddenly rose beside him. The flame turned into a spinning doorway. The Skeletal Roc flew out of the gate, and right after that Alice stepped through.

The doll held a steaming paper bag in her arms. The moment she saw Duncan, she lit up with joy and pushed the bag toward him: “Captain! Potato cakes! I brought them over for you!”

Duncan turned his head and quietly looked at the simple-minded doll in front of him. The bandages hid whatever expression he might have had, but his eyes were full of helplessness.

Alice thought for a moment, then caught on smoothly this time: “Ah, I forgot that this body of yours over here doesn’t normally need to eat.”

“I can drink tea once in a while, but I really do not need food,” Duncan said calmly, yet he still took the paper bag from Alice’s hands. “But thank you all the same.”

Alice broke into a happy grin at once. Only then did she notice Tyrian and Aiden standing not far away, watching them. She quickly waved at them: “You are here too!”

Tyrian hesitated for a moment before he led Aiden over. His expression turned a little strange as he looked at the doll who looked exactly like the Queen of Frostholm. No matter how many times he had seen this face, that hard-to-describe sense of wrongness always crept up on him again, especially when the doll opened her mouth to speak.

Alice seemed not to notice Tyrian and Aiden’s subtle expressions at all. She was just happy to see familiar faces. She raised her hand and pointed at the paper bag in Duncan’s hand: “Do you want some potato cakes? They were just made. I even poured on Lightwind Harbor’s special mixed spice!”

Before Tyrian could say anything, Duncan suddenly reacted to the doll’s words: “Wait. Did you say Lightwind Harbor’s special spice?”

Alice held her head and nodded again and again: “Yeah, yeah. Lunie bought it outside back when we were in the city-state. She said it could really open the eyes of people from the north. The taste is a bit weird, but the texture is pretty fun.”

Duncan finally understood where the strange smell drifting out of the paper bag came from.

He silently lifted his head and glanced at Tyrian: “Try one.”

Tyrian had no idea what was about to happen. He did not care much about food, and he knew very little about the tales of Lightwind Harbor's cuisine. Faced with Father's invitation, he did not overthink it and even felt a little pleased. He reached into the bag, took out a potato cake, and popped it into his mouth.

Then he just stood there, completely still.

"Looks like your spice is the real thing. It will probably take him a while to snap out of it," Duncan said as he drew his gaze back and nodded to Alice. Then he turned and pointed at the "compressed planet" floating above the beach. "Let us look at this first."

"Oh." Alice answered at once. She was a bit curious why Tyrian had suddenly started to shed tears, but she still focused her attention on the Lost Star, which had a gorgeous surface and let out a faint humming sound.

Of course she knew what it was. Before they set out, she had already known that the captain was investigating the northern fallen relic No. 2, and this strange yet beautiful sphere in front of her was clearly the core of fallen relic No. 2.

"What is it 'saying'?" Duncan asked curiously at the side.

He could share Alice's sight. Through her eyes he could see the "lines" or the information that came from Vision 001. But he could not instinctively understand those things the way Alice did. That was a gift unique to Navigator Three.

Right now, he was very curious what information this doll could pull from fallen relic No. 2.

Alice frowned slightly. After a while, she slowly said: "There is a lot of information. All kinds of error reports. Mainframe communication failure,

protocol conflict, reconstruction of runtime environment failed. It is a mess, much more chaotic than the error messages I saw last time."

Duncan asked: "Anything else? Anything like a system reboot countdown?"

"No," Alice said, shaking her head. "It is all kinds of malfunctions, and some jumbled bits of data. There are parts I cannot even understand."

After listening to Alice's report, Duncan only let out a quiet sigh and nodded slightly.

The situation was very bad, but he had more or less expected it.

Aiden stood by and stared, stunned, at the scene. Only now did he suddenly react. He bumped Tyrian's arm at once and said: "Whatever else you say, Miss Alice really can talk with that thing!"

Tyrian finally jolted back to himself, as if waking from a nightmare that had struck him out of nowhere. His whole body gave a clear shiver. Then he bent over and started coughing and retching hard.

This gave Aiden quite a scare. The bald, burly man grabbed Tyrian's arm at once. He patted Tyrian's back while he asked in a rush: "What is wrong?"

Tyrian finally recovered from the impact of that extreme spiciness mixed with a sharp, sour stench. He still could not understand how a single potato cake could leave him with such a "terrifying thrill". When he lifted his head, it still seemed as if layers of ghostly afterimages floated around his vision. In those afterimages, he even saw Father's gentle, smiling face.

He blinked and realized that Father really was here.

"This is a bit too intense. Ugh," Tyrian finally caught his breath. He stared at the half potato cake left in his hand with a strange expression. "How in the world did you make this?"

“The key lies in Lightwind Harbor’s special spice. It is enough to awaken a person’s reverence for food,” Duncan said calmly. “We have been in the south this whole time, and Lightwind Harbor’s food is the thing that left the deepest impression on me there.”

Tyrian stared blankly at the paper bag in Father’s hand and, from the bottom of his heart, understood what “reverence for food” meant.

He was very reverent, almost to the point of fear.

Just then, a howling gust of wind suddenly came from not far away and cut off their conversation.

Duncan looked toward the sound without thinking. In the faint golden light that filled the whole Harbor, he saw a current of wind wrapped in gray-white dust sweep quickly across the sky. The Ashen Wind circled above the beach for a few seconds, then came straight toward him.

The Ashen Wind gathered together, and Agatha, cool in manner and dressed in a black Goddess clergy gown, stepped out of the wind.

Chapter 745

Agatha of the city-state of Frostholm had arrived. Carried by the familiar Ashen Wind, the priestess who now also served as the city-state's Archbishop appeared before Duncan and Alice and bowed her head to him: "Good evening. I am glad to see you come in person to handle this matter."

Duncan lifted his head and glanced toward the sea: "Strictly speaking, it is still dusk."

"dusk will last for a long time yet, but people still have to live by a 'normal' daily rhythm," Agatha said. She gave Alice a small nod. "Long time no see, Miss Alice."

"Uh… ah! Long time no see!" Alice answered after a short pause. She scratched her hair in embarrassment. "There is an Agatha on the ship too, so I did not react right away."

Hearing this, a faint smile appeared at the corner of Agatha's mouth. Though her eyes were covered with a black cloth, it still felt as if a warm gaze fell on Alice. "On the ship… how is she doing lately?"

"She is doing great! Every day she makes Shirley do homework through the mirror, or she slips out to scare people when the fog rolls in, even though she says she is just going out for a walk," Alice said quickly, her face bright with joy. "Everyone likes her. Only Shirley is a bit afraid of her."

Agatha quietly listened to the doll's descriptions. At first she looked a bit surprised, but her expression slowly turned into a gentle smile. After a

while, she gave a soft nod and murmured: “So that is how it is. It sounds wonderful.”

At this moment, Tyrian finally found a chance and stepped forward: “Have the Nightwatch matters already been arranged properly at the Cathedral?”

“I came only after finishing those arrangements. Do not worry, we have plenty of people,” Agatha said offhand. Then she could not help frowning slightly and stepped back a bit without drawing attention. “Governor, is your stomach troubling you?”

Tyrian froze for a moment, then understood what she meant. Even as the “Steel Vice Admiral”, he felt a bit embarrassed. The corner of his mouth twitched, but he recovered quickly and lifted a hand to point at the paper bag in Father’s hand: “Do you want to try a potato cake?”

Agatha had no idea why the topic had suddenly jumped to this. She gave the thing in Duncan’s hand a puzzled look. Duncan raised the bag at once: “Alice made them herself. It is Lightwind Harbor style.”

“That will not be necessary,” Agatha said. At the words “Lightwind Harbor” she stepped back half a pace, but then she seemed to realize this was a bit impolite and added: “This body has no life left in it. I can no longer enjoy the world’s delicacies. Thank you for your kindness.”

Duncan glanced at Agatha’s body, covered in cracks and broken apart like a ruined doll. He knew she was telling the truth. He could only shrug in regret, then stuffed the whole bag of potato cakes straight into Tyrian’s arms: “Then you take them all. Eat them slowly when you go back.”

Tyrian took Father’s gift with a slightly blank look. His eyes swept quietly over the people present: one corpse, one Undying, one doll, and one who was his Dad, and also a corpse.

The Steel Vice Admiral finally realized, a bit late, that he was the only one here with a decent amount of living human in him. He was the unlucky one.

Duncan did not pay attention to the subtle change in Tyrian's expression. After he finally handed off the bag in his hand, he clapped his palms lightly and turned to look at the gorgeous planet still floating quietly in the air above the beach.

"This is only a beginning," he said to Agatha. "In the days to come, more and more fragments of the Sun will fall onto the Boundless Sea. Inside them will be all kinds of Lost Stars as their cores. In the long Long Night that follows, these fragments of the Sun may become the only protection for many city-states."

At his words, Agatha's expression turned serious at once: "So the Sun's disintegration is already unavoidable. Is that it?"

"Yes. It sounds terrible, but it truly cannot be avoided, and the process will only speed up," Duncan said with a small nod. "Next I will contact the Popes of the Four Gods and remind them to watch for the fallen glowing orbs on the Boundless Sea and recover them in time."

Tyrian and Agatha fell silent at the same time.

In the days that followed, no one knew how many more sunrises this world would see. The long Long Night was about to descend. Faced with that fact, even Tyrian felt a little suffocated.

Along with that feeling of suffocation, other thoughts rose quickly in Tyrian's mind.

Lost in thought, he lifted his head and looked at Duncan: "Just now, you said these fallen fragments might be the only protection for many city-states?"

“Vanna has already received a revelation from the storm Goddess, and I have also gotten information from the Abyssal Lord. From Lightwind Harbor’s experience, these fragments of the Sun really can provide a ‘sheltering’ power similar to Vision 001, though only over a small area,” Duncan said with a slight nod. “They cannot calm wide stretches of sea, but at least they can protect a single city-state.”

Tyrian’s expression grew heavier bit by bit. After a while, he spoke in a low, almost to himself: “Will it be enough?”

His quiet murmur reached everyone’s ears. Alice looked a little puzzled, while Aiden and Agatha clearly understood what Tyrian meant by “enough”. Their expressions shifted at once and turned solemn.

Duncan slowly nodded.

“I understand you,” he said in a low voice. “To be honest, no one knows how many fragments there will be by then, and no one knows if they will be enough. But if there is no strong restraint, then even if there are enough fragments, they will still never be ‘enough’.”

“The Church will step in. Our patrol fleets cover every route,” Agatha said after a brief pause for thought. “If the Church’s fleets are not enough, Frostholm’s navy is also reliable.”

“That is the most optimistic case. To be honest, I am not used to facing the future with too optimistic a mindset, especially when human nature is being tested,” Tyrian said, shaking his head. “What if even the Church is split? When the veil of night descends, every test will be magnified without limit. Even the most loyal and upright people have their own stance.”

After that, they all fell silent, and the air around them grew heavy for a moment.

Alice still watched the scene in confusion. She looked at Tyrian and Agatha, then up at the captain, and finally could not help asking: “What are you talking about?”

Duncan did not answer. He only lifted his hand and gently pressed it on Alice’s hair.

Aiden spoke from the side: “We are worried that, by then, there will not be enough fragments of the Sun to shelter every city-state in the Sanctuary World, or that some people will try to seize more sunlight. After all, this is about survival.”

With such a blunt explanation, Alice finally understood what they were discussing.

The doll’s eyes widened, and she looked a little lost. This was something she had never thought about before, a problem she had never faced.

Tyrian lowered his head and gave the paper bag in his hand a complicated look: “When that time comes, a northerner might really never again eat potato cakes from Lightwind Harbor.”

Duncan shook his head and said softly to Alice: “Do not think about it. This is not something you need to worry about. This world has always had terrible parts. It did not start today.”

When she heard the captain’s words, Alice suddenly seemed to think of something and looked up at once: “Then, when that time comes, you will step in, right? Like you did in Pland and Frostholm.”

Duncan did not answer, but Agatha quickly reacted: “Yes. The Vanished Fleet. If we add your strength on top of that, it will be much easier to keep the city-states in line and maintain basic order after the veil of night. At least it will stop the very worst from happening.”

Duncan still did not answer. He only stayed silent, neither agreeing nor denying.

His reaction made Tyrian realize something: “You are not planning to step in?”

“No, I am thinking about something else,” Duncan said, shaking his head slightly.

He turned around and fixed his gaze quietly on the Lost Star floating in midair. No one knew what he was thinking in that silence, and even Tyrian did not dare speak at this moment. Only after a long time did Duncan pull his gaze back and break the silence in a soft voice: “If the day truly comes when things are at their very worst, I may have to do something that only I can do. That will probably mean going very far away, and maybe being gone for a very long time.”

In that moment, Tyrian seemed to faintly sense something. Some premonition, born from instinct, made the edges of his vision blur and tremble with light and shadow. For an instant, he felt as if Father’s figure was already standing in a place so distant he could never reach it. Though they were close enough to touch right now, some invisible Veil seemed to be drawing shut between them, as if it meant to separate them into two different times and spaces.

That invisible Veil seemed filled with starlight.

But the feeling vanished in an instant. Tyrian felt his thoughts break off for half a beat, and when he tried to recall what he had just sensed, only endless emptiness remained.

Duncan turned his head. On his bandage-covered face, the only part left bare, his eyes, held a calm light.

“There is no need to worry too much. Even in the very worst case, flame will once again light up this world. Hard times are always only temporary.”

Father’s words seemed to carry another meaning.

But Tyrian had no chance to ask more. A surge of spirit form flame suddenly appeared on the beach and slowly traced out a whirlpool.

Father was getting ready to leave.

“I still have many things to do,” Duncan said as he waved to Tyrian, Aiden, and Agatha. He walked toward the flame while he spoke: “Put more of your effort into facing the coming veil of night and do not overthink the rest. And do not worry about the graveyard district.”

The flame rose and then shot into the sky like a backward-falling meteor, quickly vanishing from Tyrian and Agatha’s sight.

Chapter 746: The Phantom That Passed By

The backward-flying shooting star slowly went farther away and finally vanished.

On the wide shoreline, only Tyrian, Aiden, and Agatha remained.

The ancient Lost Star still floated quietly above the sand. Slow clouds drifted across its surface as it let out a faint, almost sobbing howl. A dozen meters away lay the calm sea. Under the pale golden sunlight, the water looked like a slowly rising and falling mirror, and the tiny waves were much gentler than on other days.

In this long dusk, Tyrian finally broke the silence: “Gatekeeper, do you think that if the Sun really breaks apart completely, the Church will still have enough power to keep order between the city-states?”

Agatha did not answer. Faced with this sharp question, she stayed quiet for a long time. A year ago, she would have given a firm yes without a second thought.

Agatha knew she was no longer as devout and firm as before. That unconditional faith had cracked during the mirror world disaster in Frostholm, and thoughts slipped in through that gap.

But after hesitating, she still nodded lightly: “I believe my Brothers and Sisters will do their best… and so will They.”

“An answer that comes after thinking is not as firm as a believer’s, but in a situation like this it actually feels more reassuring,” Tyrian let out a slow breath, and a faint smile appeared on his face. “No matter what, we will do our best. I believe the other city-states will too.”

Agatha said nothing. She only nodded quietly, then turned around. Her figure faded into a swirling Pale Wind and drifted away.

Aiden had stood quietly to the side the whole time. Only now did he speak, a bit hesitant: “…What are you planning to do next?”

“First, have City Hall do everything it can before sunset. I want every person in the city-state to get through the coming Long Night safely. Second, order the fleet to make full preparations. I want every warship in its best state. No matter how long this night lasts, they must be ready to fight at any moment. Third…”

Tyrian paused for a few seconds and lowered his head to glance at the bag in his hand.

“Third, tell everyone to eat when they should eat, sleep when they should sleep, and live well. Ten thousand years ago, the city-builders raised the city-states in the Dark Age after the old kingdom collapsed. We will also find a way through this crisis… Doomsday is not here yet.”

“Yes, Captain!”

Flames cut across the sunset, leaving a brief bright scar between the clouds, then fell onto the slope before the cemetery. The spirit form flames slowly faded, and Duncan’s figure took shape out of the fire.

Alice had already gone back to the Vanished, while Duncan returned to the cemetery alone. He slowly walked up the slope he had taken many times before. In the slanting, dim evening glow, his shadow stretched long and wavered over the old stone path.

It was very quiet around him. Most people in the city had probably already gone home. There were almost no vehicles on the distant avenue. Only a few steam walkers were strolling down the streets. Workers sent by City Hall were checking the street lamps and gas pipes, and black-clad guards holding consecrated lanterns were making sure all the veil of night Sanctuary Worlds were in the right state. They all looked busy.

Duncan drew back his gaze from the distance and kept walking up.

He stopped at the cemetery gate.

A figure he had not expected yet found familiar stood outside the gate. It was a girl of thirteen or fourteen, wrapped in a thick light gray winter coat. She wore a fluffy knitted hat and gloves, bundled up like a soft ball of yarn. She stood at the gate, sometimes stamping her feet, sometimes walking around the entrance, then looking toward the slope.

It was Annie. She looked as if she had been waiting here for a long time.

Duncan frowned and walked quickly toward the cemetery gate. Annie saw him too. The young lady’s face lit up, and she ran down the slope toward him.

“Uncle Caretaker!” Annie called out happily and stopped at the edge of the open space before the gate. “I came just now and saw there was no one in the warden’s cabin. The black-clothed guards said you had gone out…”

“Curfew is about to start. City Hall told all residents to go home. Why did you run here?” Duncan frowned. His voice, muffled under the bandages, sounded low and a bit frightening. “It is not safe outside.”

“I know. I was just about to go home,” Annie nodded at once. She was not afraid of Duncan in his all-black clothes, wrapped in bandages, gloomy and stern. Instead, she reached into her coat, took out a small packet, and

pushed it into Duncan's hand. "This is herbal tea… please take it. And then… I probably won't be coming for a long time."

Duncan looked at the paper packet in his hand, a bit surprised. He stayed silent for a few seconds before softening his tone: "Do you know what is going to happen?"

"…The Sun is not right, is it?" Annie raised her head and looked into Duncan's gloomy, sunken eyes. "The sunset has lasted for a long time already, and it still has not gone all the way down… I heard a nun say that if the Sun sets this time, it might take a very, very long time before it rises again… Mom said the temperature might keep falling then, or maybe stop halfway, and the worst will be the farms…"

She stopped. What came after that seemed too complicated for her. It was hard to understand, and harder to repeat.

Duncan stayed quiet for a while, then bent down a little: "Are you afraid?"

Annie shook her head, then stopped, and hesitantly nodded.

She did not really understand what was happening now, and she could not really picture what things would become later. Compared with the simple, obvious threat of the mud monsters that had once spread through the city, a slowly sinking Sun was a disaster much harder to grasp for a thirteen-year-old child.

But she could feel, from the lords' reactions, the same tense, heavy mood as during the mirror world disaster. She had already been through it once.

"If the Sun never rises again, will we have to carry consecrated lanterns and tattoo runes on our eyelids before we can go outside?" Annie asked. "Like those ascetic monks—they always stand guard in dark places…"

For a moment Duncan did not know how to answer. He thought for a long time before speaking softly: "…The Sun will rise again. If the Sun does not

rise, then something else will light up the sky."

Annie seemed not to understand, yet also seemed to think of something. Her eyes widened in surprise: "Is it you? Will you light up the sky?"

"…Go home," Duncan said with a smile. The bandages wrapped around his face hid it, leaving only a curve at the corner of his eyes. He brushed some dust off Annie's clothes, not sure when it had settled there, and then looked up at the dimming glow over the far roofs. "It is getting dark… and thank you for the herbal tea."

"Mm!"

It was getting dark—though it might still take a while.

Outside the antique shop's window, the last splendor of the sunset had already begun to fade, yet the world still refused to sink into full darkness.

Duncan drew back the gaze with which he had watched Annie leave on the northern cemetery slope, and his eyes passed through the old shop's window to look at the Pland streets in the evening.

The streets were already empty. Even the noisiest children had been taken home by the lords of their households. The alleys of the Lower City, which always felt too crowded and lively, now looked cold and deserted, as if the place had become an empty city.

But another steam walker broke the silence outside the window. With the clacking of its steam engine, the huge spider machine walked slowly down the street. Steam hissed from the exhaust port at the back, and the strips of scripture cloth hanging on its armor plates fluttered in the wind. Two guardians in Deep Sea Church uniforms stood on its back, announcing the new veil of night notice that the Grand Cathedral had just issued. It included the new curfew order and changes to the city's functions during the veil of night.

Even though Pland now had a safe veil of night after the Black Sun incident, the city-state still felt tense.

No one knew whether the city's "safe veil of night" would stay safe once the night stretched into tens of days. Even fewer knew whether, with sunlight absent for so long, something else might grow in the dark sea and crawl onto the shore under cover of night to invade the city-state.

If even Pland felt like this, what would the other city-states on the Boundless Sea be like now?

As the sunset grew darker and murkier, Duncan's thoughts drifted. Then he put down the newspaper in his hand and got ready to stand up and switch on the electric lamp by the stairs.

Just then, a figure suddenly appeared at the edge of his vision.

By a shelf in the corner of the antique shop's first floor, that figure appeared out of nowhere. It looked like a traveler with a hunched back, as if he had been walking on some long journey for who knew how long. He wore a tattered white robe whose original look could no longer be seen, his body leaning forward a little as he took slow steps toward the counter.

Duncan slowly stood up and stared at the figure coming toward him.

Yet the figure seemed not to see Duncan. It was as if he walked in another, parallel layer of time and space, his gaze fixed on some far-off, shapeless place. He walked straight through the shelf and moved on slowly like a ghost.

As this happened, Duncan finally began to see the traveler's face clearly. He saw an old face, with deep wrinkles and skin that looked almost withered, as if time itself had frozen there. Then, all at once, that old face became young again. It turned into the face of a young man who had just set out on his journey, and the hunched body straightened.

A second later he turned into an old man again. His figure passed through the counter and was about to brush right past Duncan.

But suddenly he stopped.

He seemed to see Duncan—or perhaps only some phantom shape. His whole body went stiff as he stopped. His eyes opened wide, staring straight in this direction.

Duncan found that he could not read any clear emotion from that trembling face. Was it surprise? Fear? Despair? Or the sudden sight of hope?

Chapter 747: Sunset

Seventy-two hours later, the long sunset finally began to draw to an end. At the far edge of the Boundless Sea, only a thin golden rim of the glorious Sun Wheel and part of its rune rings still rested on the sea. In the refraction of the clouds, the evening glow grew more splendid, yet also more dim.

The people of this world had no time to admire the beauty of the sunset. To most, that radiant glow only meant that the veil of night was near. Now the whole world was slowly stepping into what might be the longest veil of night in history.

In the city-state of Morka, two steam walkers bearing the crest of Truth Academy were walking down the streets. Fully armed Knowledge Guards moved beside the machines, checking the streets while urging citizens to hurry home. In the fading light, the shadows of warriors and spider automatons stretched long and swayed, melting into the shadows between the streets and the buildings by the road.

In Cold Harbor, the last supply transfer had already ended. The notice that the subway stations would be temporarily shut down echoed in every station. Guardians sealed every door leading to the underground facilities and guarded each entrance and exit. At sunset, holy steam and incense would be sent into the pipes until the underground of the city-state was fully purified. After that, the subway would reopen, but it would run carefully under the new schedule and safety rules.

After all, the veil of night might last one to two months. The city-state could not completely shut down for so long. During these seventy-two hours of

dusk, the administrators and scholars of the city-state had already drawn up a new “timetable” and set of safety rules for the long Long Night, to keep the city’s basic functions running as well as possible while the veil of night lasted.

The new timetable and safety rules had never been tested in practice. There had not even been time for more careful discussion. Each city-state would test the feasibility of its own “veil of night plan” in this long darkness before the Sun rose again.

And in distant Lunsa, gunfire had once broken the city’s calm and almost snapped people’s taut nerves. Suntists took the chance to move, stirring up the anxious citizens and preaching that the true Sun god would be reborn in the veil of night. Misled by them, their congregation set fires in the Lower City and tried to seize the Cathedral on the city’s edge.

The chaos was quickly put down. The flamebearers of the Flamebearer Church took control of the situation at once, but the tension in the city-state had already risen…

…

A mechanical spider moved its long jointed legs as it walked down a weathered old street in the city-state. The loudspeaker mounted on the machine’s head gave out a slightly distorted voice that echoed through the alleys:

“Attention, all citizens… There are thirty minutes left before sunset. Please return home as soon as possible… The new curfew will last twelve hours. After that, the temporary city schedule will take effect…

“…Steam, electricity, and gas will be supplied as usual. Workers in related posts may pass checkpoints with their permits… All veil of night Sanctuary Worlds will stay open until sunrise…

“citizens have the duty to help watch over the city’s basic facilities… If you find a street lamp out or steam supply weak, please report at once to the nearest Cathedral or security post…

“…If you notice abnormal shadows in your home, or hear strange sounds from underground, please seek help from the Knowledge Guards on the streets…

“Please keep calm and relaxed, citizens. We are going through a special anomaly. The city-state has enough power to protect everyone. Please follow the new schedule and safety rules, keep your life in order, and keep your body and mind healthy…”

The broadcast grew farther and farther away, until it became just a faint, distorted wind in the ears. Outside the window of the Harbor Inn, the gas lamp had already been lit. Its lonely light drove back the darkness heavy with malice and lit up the empty street. Aside from the occasional guardian passing the intersection on patrol, there were no more pedestrians to be seen.

It was hard to imagine that only a few days ago this place had been full of traffic and crowds.

Lawrence drew his gaze back from the window, let out a soft breath, and bent over his diary, writing line after line:

“Year xx, month x, day x. We are still docked at the Harbor of Faerun. This city-state has already done all it can to prepare for the coming night, and now the Sun is about to vanish below the sea…

“My crew members do not feel fear. Instead, they seem… excited, fearless of heaven and earth. The divine blessing of the Vanished fills them with confidence and makes them believe they have enough strength to face whatever comes. That is not a bad thing.

“Faerun is not a very rich city-state, but its situation is still alright. Everyone here is doing their best to calm the people around them and to gather what they need to get through the night… Before dinner, the inn’s boss said he had gotten enough fuel and had filled the warehouse with emergency food and medicine, so even if the curfew grows longer, they can still hold out…

“This city-state lies near the southwest border, and it seems it is used to such ‘restless’ times. No one knows what will happen next. The people here try not to talk about the worst possibilities and instead pour all their effort into daily life. That is a valuable trait. It lets Faerun bear more pressure than the rich city-states in the Central Seas…

“But I am worried about other things—the sealed objects on the ship, and the sealed objects in the city-state.

“And there are those ships still sailing out on the distant sea. Even if they try their best to return, many still cannot reach the Harbor in time. The Sun is about to set. Perhaps many captains and sailors are still on the Boundless Sea. It takes at least seven days to sail from the middle of the southwestern route to the nearest city-state, and the situation on those distant routes is even worse… In a lasting veil of night, no one knows what changes this sea will undergo…”

A faint cool draft brushed past his ear. Lawrence stopped writing and sighed softly.

He raised his head and looked at the window facing the Harbor district. His gaze passed over the docks. He could see two more large cargo ships appearing at the far sea horizon, sounding their horns as they drew toward the coast. Several small fast boats bearing Church emblems shot out from the docks like arrows, heading toward the two ships that had requested to

dock, ready to carry out boarding checks and the necessary divine blessing before they came into port.

In a corner of the window, a hazy figure slowly appeared on the glass surface and waved at Lawrence, who was looking into the distance.

“Two more ships coming in, and both big ones,” Lawrence said softly. “All the docks in Faerun are almost full.”

“In the past seventy-two hours, four times the usual number of ships have docked in Faerun, and more than half of them came here just to ‘take shelter’,” the hazy figure on the glass said casually, its voice carrying a faint, airy tremor. “They are already the lucky ones. The ones who cannot make it back do not even know what to do.”

“…Every long-distance ship has a small Cathedral and a shipboard Father, but those measures were made to deal with normal nights,” Lawrence sighed and shook his head. “They gave twenty-four hours after sunset as the final time limit for normal docking. After that, any returning ship will not be allowed to come straight up to the city-state. They will have stayed in the veil of night too long. They will no longer be safe.”

“…The White Oak once had the same ‘treatment’,” Martha said. “I remember you told me—it was after the first time you met the Vanished.”

Lawrence shrugged and said nothing.

Martha stayed quiet for a moment before speaking again: “…If the Sun keeps moving like this from now on, people will get used to it sooner or later. The chaos will only be temporary, just like the city-states that held on through the Dark Age. After the old kingdom fell, they found new ways to continue. As long as life survives, it always finds a way.”

Lawrence knew these were not the kind of words Martha would normally say. She was an outstanding explorer and captain, but not a philosopher.

Yet he still felt a hint of comfort and warmth in her words.

“You are right, Martha,” he nodded lightly. “There will always be a way out…”

High in the sky, the pale World’s Wound slowly appeared behind the clouds. The thinning sunlight was fading from the sea, and at some point a hazy mist had risen nearby, rising and falling with the waves.

The towering bow of the Vanished cut through the waves, sailing into the distance through the evening mist. The half-transparent spirit form sails on its tall masts billowed without wind. The Radiant Star followed close by, its half-real, half-unreal hull rising and falling on the waves as if it might slip into another dimension at any moment.

News came from Lightwind Harbor. The last civilian cargo ship that could return before sunset had already docked at the pier. The city navy was setting up posts and markers in the nearby waters and was moving a mobile Harbor, equipped with a high-power steam core and Cathedral facilities, to the sea between the city-state and the “glowing geometric body”. After that, any ship returning to the city would have to stop at that temporary Harbor, and only after strict inspection and quarantine would it be allowed to come any closer.

Duncan stood on the foredeck, listening as Morris relayed the situation from Lightwind Harbor, and nodded slightly: “Lawrence is in the city-state of Faerun right now. He said they left a twenty-four-hour window after nightfall for returning ships. When that window closes, the returners must also stop at a temporary dock near the city-state and undergo inspection and quarantine.”

“Each city-state is making its own response plan based on its own situation and experience, but no one knows which one will work best,” Vanna said beside him. “Even so, getting through the first veil of night should not be

too hard. Even with stored supplies alone, most city-states can safely wait for sunrise. What is truly worrying… is what comes after."

Duncan said nothing. He only thought in silence.

After quite a while, he suddenly spoke: "What about the sightings of the 'End Survey Team'?"

"Just as you guessed—there have also been scattered reports of sightings in other parts of the world," Vanna nodded. "I confirmed it with Helena, Your Eminence. She said that starting a few days ago, there have been at least five incidents within the Deep Sea Church's sphere of influence where people 'saw a phantom as if from another time and space suddenly appear'. After comparison and confirmation, at least three of them are very likely to have been the End Survey Team carrying out their observations at the End of Time."

Duncan thought for a moment and nodded slightly.

At the edge of his vision, the last strand of evening glow finally faded from the sea.

Night fell.

Chapter 748: An Uninvited Guest on the Ship

The long dusk had ended, and the veil of night had descended.

The electric lights came on, driving the darkness from the room. Taran Ael stood at the window, frowning as he stared at the streets outside. The glow of the gas lamps lit the road, and now and then he saw patrolling Knowledge Guards with watch dogs appear near the corners. Aside from that, the whole city seemed dead under the veil of night, empty and silent.

He did not know how much time had passed before he pulled his gaze back from the window and looked at the stacks of sorted notes and books on his desk. He let out a barely audible sigh.

He had sorted all this before the Sun set. Next, he needed to pack everything and send it to the academy's Grand Library. There, a new office waited for him, blessed by the God of Wisdom and guarded by many holy wards, where he could safely carry out his research and reading.

But only a few scholars ever qualified to get a "safe room" in the Grand Library. For most people, once the Sun set, "reading" became a taboo. For safety, all books had to be sealed away for the whole duration of this veil of night, until the next sunrise. This was also part of the "veil of night Ban" that the Administration Hall had just issued.

At the same time, teaching in all schools also had to stop. The young students did not yet have the strength or experience to deal with the

monsters that came chasing from the Spirit Realm and the Abyssal Deep Sea. It was far too dangerous.

Of course, some people thought things were not so bad in Lightwind Harbor. The glowing geometric body beside the city-state had a power similar to the Sun. Within its “sunlight”, people might still live and work as normal and carry on their research. But that was only a guess. No one had ever tested the power of that glowing geometric body during such a long veil of night, nor knew the limits of its protection. They could not risk it.

As far as Taran Ael knew, a group of scholars was already running tests near the glowing geometric body. They were fully armed and protected by equally armed Guardians. At different times and places, they tried to “read under the veil of night” to check how well the “sunlight” could protect them.

But even Taran Ael did not know how long these tests would last or how many times they would need to be repeated.

The door opened, and his young apprentice Joshua walked into the room, pushing a small cart. He froze a little when he saw his Teacher and asked: “…You still haven’t gone to the Grand Library?”

“I’ll go with the next group,” Taran Ael said casually, lifting a hand to point at the things on the desk. “Everything is already sorted. Just take these from the desk. Leave the rest here… I’ll be back after dawn.”

“Alright, Teacher.” Joshua answered honestly, then quietly began tying up and packing the sorted books and papers, moving them onto the small cart. He kept his head lowered the whole time, as if trying not to see the words on the pages, or perhaps to avoid meeting his Teacher’s eyes.

“After you finish tidying up here, go home with the others,” Taran said suddenly as he looked at his young apprentice. “You’re on holiday.”

“Can I go to the Grand Library with you?” Joshua hesitated for a moment, then looked up. “I… still have a paper I haven’t finished.”

“So now you decide to be motivated?” Taran raised an eyebrow and spoke on purpose in a teasing tone: “Aren’t you always shouting about wanting a break?”

Joshua pressed his lips together, looking a little embarrassed: “I…”

“Alright, I’m joking,” Taran laughed and shook his head gently. “Go home. Stop thinking about your paper. Those ‘safe rooms’ in the Grand Library are not that safe either. A seasoned scholar like me knows how to work carefully with those wards, but a young man like you is not ready yet… Even if the safe room blocks the bodies of the malevolent spirits, the muttering from the books can still drive you mad.

“Take your break. Rest well and build up your strength. We’ll still have long days ahead of us… and when that time comes, you won’t get such a comfortable holiday.”

Hearing his Teacher’s words, Joshua only nodded slowly. After hesitating for a while, he finally gathered his courage to ask: “Will it really get light again afterward?”

“…Yes, it will,” Taran looked into his apprentice’s eyes and spoke with extra seriousness. “Remember? You and I calculated the Sun’s rate of descent together, and it sank below the sea horizon right on time according to our numbers. It will rise again according to the same calculations. It just needs some time.”

The tense look on the young man’s face finally eased a little. He quietly packed the rest of the things, respectfully said goodbye to his Teacher, then pushed the cart out of the room.

Taran Ael watched Joshua’s back as he left. After quite a while, he suddenly turned his head toward the window and said: “How long do you plan to stand there watching?”

The air near the window twisted at once, and the figure of Truth Keeper Ted Lier emerged from it out of thin air: “I just didn’t want to disturb your talk with your apprentice.”

“…You still dare to use ‘sacred miracles’ to travel?” Taran gave the Truth Keeper a sidelong glance. “Did you forget what happened last time with that Subspace butterfly stroke?”

Ted’s expression twisted at once, then he forced down the twitch at the corner of his eye: “Of course I made sure it was safe… Do you really have to hold such a grudge?”

Taran did not answer. He just quietly raised a middle finger.

The corner of Ted’s mouth twitched again, then turned into an awkward smile.

“Shouldn’t you be leading your Guardians to protect the city’s night right now?” Taran asked casually. “How do you still have time to come here and cause trouble?”

“I finally don’t have to look at that pile of rushed, patched-together papers from those rookies. I’m in a very good mood now, so I came to chat with you—does that reason work?”

Taran still said nothing. He only looked quietly at the Truth Keeper in front of him.

“…Fine. I’m here to personally escort the second group of scholars, including you, to the Grand Library,” Ted shrugged. “A squad of Knowledge Guards is already waiting downstairs. When the others are ready, you’ll come with me.”

“Is that really necessary? A Truth Keeper escorting us in person?” Taran frowned. “It’s only a ten-minute drive from here to the Grand Library. I can just drive myself…”

“In the city-state of Morka, two scholars vanished into thin air on their way to take shelter in the library—the night swallowed them,” Ted cut him off. The Truth Keeper’s face grew serious. “The veil of night has become more dangerous than we thought. And the ‘knowledge’ in your head… is especially sweet to ‘them’.”

Taran Ael froze for a second, then silently turned and walked toward a low cabinet nearby.

“What are you doing?” Ted asked curiously when he saw this.

“Taking my revolver, and a knife and charm amulet for self-defense.”

…

Pages turned in the room. Morris compared the notes he had written before and scribbled in a thick notebook, stopping from time to time to think and adjust his line of thought.

His big notebook was filled with dense lines of writing and abstract symbols, and many dizzying diagrams that sketched the shape of this world.

He was finishing his most important project: trying to build a “model” that could explain the whole world, from the Great Annihilation as the starting point, to the beginning of the Deep Sea era, up to the current state of this “Sanctuary World”, and its possible future.

He had worked on this research for a very long time, and only now, as the world neared its end, did he see a chance to complete it.

Not far from Morris’s desk sat Shirley, who was nodding off, and Dog, who was fully focused on the documents.

After an unknown while, a faint, muffled whisper suddenly sounded by Morris’s ear.

As the whisper rose, a cold current suddenly flooded the whole cabin. The room seemed to turn into an ice cave at once. The chill gathered on the ceiling as if it were solid, turning into strands of white fog that drooped down. In the fog, invisible shadows slowly seeped out and stretched a tendril toward Morris…

Morris did not even lift his head. He kept writing in the notebook and said casually: “Knock it down.”

Before he finished speaking, Dog had already turned into a whirlwind made of shattered bones and black smoke. Fragments of bone and dark mist howled across the ceiling and, in the blink of an eye, devoured the twisted entity that had come chasing after knowledge.

In the next second, Dog’s form returned to normal and dropped back onto the floor.

Shirley jerked awake with a start: “Ah… huh?! What happened?!”

“Another shadow chasing after knowledge,” Dog muttered offhand, turning his head to glance at Shirley. “…Go back to sleep. It wasn’t coming for you.”

Shirley thought for a moment, then nodded: “Oh.”

She simply crawled over beside Dog and half lay down leaning against him. A second later, she was already snoring softly.

Morris stopped what he was doing and looked up, giving Shirley a helpless look. He sighed once, then lowered his head again and solemnly added the last footnote on this page.

And the moment he wrote the last letter, a strange voice suddenly came into his ears—

“An excellent study… You are already pacing before the last gate of Truth.”

Morris jolted in surprise and snapped his head up toward the source of the voice.

A figure in a worn white robe was sitting quietly beside him, wearing a gentle smile and looking at the open notes and papers on the desk.

Morris’s muscles tensed at once. In a blink, his hand went for the revolver under the desk. Dog reacted at the same time and sprang to his feet. Shirley let out an “ow” as she fell to the floor, and then she too saw the uninvited guest who had appeared in the room. Her eyes went wide, and a bone spike shot from behind her like an arrow, as if it would stab the intruder in the next second— Yet the figure in the worn white robe only sat there quietly, as if unaware of the sudden tension and hostility around him, still absorbed in Morris’s manuscripts.

After two or three seconds, he slowly raised his head, still wearing that gentle smile: “I want to speak with your captain.”

Chapter 749: Walking Against the Light

The captain had already arrived.

Almost the moment the uninvited guest in the white robe finished speaking, a column of swirling green flame rose in the room, and a figure stepped out of the fire.

Shirley jumped up the instant she saw Duncan: “Captain, Captain! A Ender suddenly showed up over here just now! This one seems to be the not-crazy kind, and he says he wants to talk to you…”

“I know,” Duncan raised a hand to cut off Shirley’s excited shouting, his gaze already fixed on the uninvited guest. “I was wondering how long you would wait before you appeared in front of me—didn’t expect it to be this soon.”

“You knew I would come?” the old man in the white robe asked casually. Though his words showed doubt and surprise, his face stayed very calm.

“You were bound to come sooner or later, because ‘dusk’ has already begun. Any member of the End Survey Group who still has a clear mind at this moment should be very willing to meet me, and I also very much want to talk with you,” Duncan said as he let his gaze sweep around the room. “…This isn’t a good place to talk. We can move somewhere else to speak.”

As soon as he finished, Shirley, Dog, and Morris—who was in the middle of casting all kinds of blessings on himself—started nodding hard in

agreement…

The uninvited guest seemed not to notice their reaction. He only looked at Duncan: “That’s fine. Let’s go somewhere closer to Subspace. I’ll feel a bit more comfortable there.”

Closer to Subspace? Duncan frowned slightly at those words, but after a brief silence he still nodded slowly: “Alright.”

When Morris heard this, his eyes widened a little without thinking: “Captain, are you sure you want to bring—”

“It’s fine,” Duncan waved his hand. “I know what I’m doing. Shirley, go to the captain’s cabin and bring me that brass consecrated lantern.”

Before long, Duncan was holding the brass consecrated lantern and walking quietly with the uninvited guest in the worn white robe through the lower decks of the Vanished. They had already passed the cargo hold of light Inversion and were now on the last corridor; the stairs leading to the bottom of the hold stood at its far end.

The brass consecrated lantern shed a dim green flame, and its light drove back the gloom around them. In the empty corridor at the bottom of the ship, only the echo of footsteps could be heard in most moments—two sets of them. But sometimes Duncan noticed that only his own footsteps were sounding. The Ender beside him seemed not fully in the current Mortal Realm. At times he was like a weightless spirit form, walking on the old wooden boards without making any sound. At other times, even his presence seemed close to fading, as if he had suddenly gone somewhere very far away…

It was very strange, but Duncan stayed polite and did not ask.

Only when they neared the last door did the Ender finally break the silence: “You actually do not need this lantern—this lantern was prepared for a

mortal.”

Duncan’s steps paused for a moment. He was quiet, then walked on: “But this ship needs it.”

“…You are truly full of goodwill,” the Ender said softly, and his tone seemed sincerely admiring.

“If you had asked me not long ago, I never would have imagined that one day I would bring a Ender here—and in such a calm mood,” Duncan said casually. “Our first contact with your people was not pleasant.”

“Is it possible that I was also among those who first made contact with you?” The white-robed Ender showed a faint, hard-to-read smile. “At least, I was one of them.”

Duncan turned his head and studied the man’s face carefully in the lantern light.

He saw an old traveler in a white robe, his back bent. The lines on his face looked carved by time itself. His sunken eyes held a faint, metallic gold sheen. His bearing was calm, his smile mild, and only the years seemed to flow quietly in the depths of his gaze.

Duncan drew back his gaze and turned his head forward again as he continued walking: “I don’t know. I don’t remember this face of yours. In any case, whether you were among the ones I dragged onto the ship back then doesn’t matter. What matters is that right now, here you are, talking to me.”

“It seems you already understand us very well.”

Duncan neither agreed nor denied it. He had already reached the last door and was reaching for the handle.

“We’re here. This is the place on the ship closest to Subspace.”

As he spoke, he pushed the dark wooden door open in one motion, and the structure of the lowest hold came into view.

Ever-burning lamp light lit the cabin. The once shattered structure of the lower hold had been repaired in the Lightwind Harbor incident and was now whole again. The solid hull that had grown from the Elder Gods' spine closed in on all sides, blocking the chaotic light flows and murmurs projecting in from Subspace. That eerie wooden door that led straight into Subspace still stood in the depths of the hold, its panels tightly shut, silent and unmoving.

Duncan led his "guest" into the cabin. The Ender followed right behind him, then lifted his head to look over the walls and ceiling and let out a sigh: "Ah… you have already repaired this place…"

"You know quite a lot," Duncan said as he casually hung the consecrated lantern on a nearby pillar and glanced back. "Did some of your people come here in a timeline I don't know about?"

"I once saw its wreckage—maybe in the past, maybe in the future," the old man in the white robe said, as if recalling something, his brow slightly furrowed. "…It broke apart in flame and fell into darkness. The real and grand sight of it was gripping."

Duncan did not answer that topic. He had been thinking about many things along the way. Now he took a moment to put his words in order before asking: "How many members of the End Survey Group are still sane like you?"

Then he paused and added: "I mean in the current time node."

The old man in the white robe was silent for a while, his face still calm: "Only me."

Duncan felt as if his breath and heartbeat both stopped for half a beat.

Then he heard the voice of the old man in white again: “Captain, do you know what it feels like to grope around in the dark?”

This last Critt who still held on to clarity and reason spoke calmly, slowly spreading his hands as if that eternal darkness still lay before his eyes—

“‘End Survey Group’… it has really been a long time since I last heard that name. In the first instant after we set out, that name already turned to dust in history.

“The ‘time’ of this world is limited. This was something we knew from the very beginning. The whole Boundless Sea, the whole Deep Sea era, was like a delicate clock whose running time had been set in advance. We knew it could only tick for a certain stretch, and our only hope was to find a chance to ‘wind it up’ again before the hands stopped…

“That wise follower of yours is already close to building the whole shape of the ‘world’. He was the first to add ‘time’ as an axis into the World Model. In our eyes, this axis looks even more… real, hard, and cold.

“Our task was to move along the time axis and, at every fork that could create a history branch, to observe and give mental guidance, doing everything possible to extend the life of the Sanctuary World while looking for a way to keep going beyond the End of Time.

“From our own experience, this process felt a bit like… walking against the light.

“The day Vision 001 was first lit in the test field was the starting point of that light. It was the most stable moment of the whole Sanctuary World. Everything had just been born, resources were abundant, the timelines were firm, and everything looked so good it seemed as if it could last forever. We set out from that bright morning of sunlight and left the light behind us, walking all the way toward the darkness at the end.

“As we moved away from the ‘starting point’, we saw the world slowly decline. All the small, unavoidable hidden flaws left from the beginning of creation gradually grew and turned into all kinds of deadly threats. The light faded, and the darkness grew. We turned our backs to the sunlight and walked toward the veil of night; the farther we went, the darker it became. We did everything we could to make adjustments, watching the possibilities along the time axis in the dimming glow, hoping to delay the coming of the dark… In a way, we succeeded.

“This Sanctuary World’s original ‘design lifespan’ was eight thousand years. By avoiding waste, easing chaos, and lowering the load on the Sun, it has already run two thousand years past that.

“But before the endless river of time, our success is tiny and doomed to be worn away completely.

“At the end of the time axis there is always only darkness. No matter how we tried to carry the light from the ‘starting point’ as far as we could into the future, or to pick up stray sparks along this road that kept getting darker, we could not light up that time end that loomed like a boundless black wall… We slammed into that endless dark, groped around, and came back with nothing. Then we recalibrated the whole time axis, checked every possibility again, did everything we could to push the future further forward, and then crashed into the dark again, over and over… countless times.”

The old man in the white robe lifted his head and cast a gaze toward some dark corner in the dim cabin. After quite a while, he went on: “There is no road ahead—that was the last sentence left by the first of us to lose his mind before he left. As a forward squad member, he stayed at the time end longer than any of us. He went through every possibility and in the end chose to give up, and even chose… to go back to the past, to ‘correct’ those wasted days.

“That was the first ‘Ender’ the world spoke of… He only entered a runaway state not long ago, and it has been so long since I last saw him that I can no longer remember his name.”

Duncan listened in silence. After a long time, he finally said: “And you held on to your sanity until the very end and have come to stand in front of me still clear-headed.”

“Yes,” the old man in the white robe turned his head, his eyes falling on Duncan. “Because in the current time node, I entered your field of view—when the order of the world is on the verge of collapse, the cause can come after the effect.”

Chapter 750: Future of Fire

When the world was close to the End, cause and effect also slowly fell into chaos. It was not that the last clear-headed Ender walked up to Duncan. Instead, in Duncan's sight, a Ender who would be the last to stay sane "appeared."

But to the two people involved, it did not seem important which of these was cause and which was effect.

"What is your name?" Duncan looked at the old man in the white robe in front of him and suddenly felt a bit curious.

Faced with such a simple question, the traveler in the worn white robe frowned deeply. He thought for quite a while, then lightly shook his head and said: "I do not really remember. The last time I used a 'name' seems to have been a long time ago… but if you are willing, you can call me Critt."

"Critt?" Duncan frowned. "That is the name of your people."

"Oh, right. No wonder it sounded so familiar." The old man showed a look of sudden understanding, and a faint smile appeared on his face. "That is fine. Call me that. I like this name."

Duncan stayed quiet for a moment, then nodded lightly: "All right, Critt. I have a few questions."

"Please ask. I have a lot of time this trip."

"The first question. Why did you choose to meet me at this time?" Duncan looked into the old man's eyes. His tone was very serious. "What is the

purpose of this Window Interval?”

“We have actually been looking for a chance to make direct contact with you. By ‘we’ I mean those of us who are still sane.” When Critt answered this question, there was a barely noticeable moment of hesitation, but he still gave an answer quickly. “However, contacting you is a very hard thing. In fact, before today we tried once already. It was just that… we missed that Window Interval.”

“You missed a window?” Duncan looked puzzled. “What do you mean?”

“We came too early, Captain.” Critt spoke in a calm voice.

Duncan froze for a moment. After a very brief thought, he suddenly understood what Critt meant: “You mean those three who appeared on the Vanished back then…”

“Yes, we came too early.” Critt nodded slightly and repeated those few words. “When we found that it was not the year 1900, the Window Interval had already ended. That was the biggest ‘linear runaway state incident’ we had met since we set out. From that day on, many things started to slip out of control. But in the end… it seems everything still stayed on its set track. Duncan Abnomar still set out on his last voyage, even after learning his ending ahead of time.”

Just from these few short sentences, a storm of thoughts rose in Duncan’s mind.

The Enders, or the so-called End Survey Team, knew the truth about him as the bearer of the Flame Usurper. They knew he was an outside soul that had taken over Duncan Abnomar’s body. Duncan had already guessed this part long ago. But the other part of the truth was completely beyond his expectations.

In the memories of Tyrian and Lucretia, those “uninvited guests” who had suddenly appeared on the Vanished back then, those Enders who had talked deep into the night with Duncan Abnomar… they had actually come looking for him?

Duncan quickly sorted out the information in Critt’s words and slowly reacted: “So you originally did not plan to contact… ‘him’?”

“Yes. We revealed his ending ahead of time to one who was about to go to the dead.” Critt nodded slowly. “I know what you want to say, but the truth is, when we appeared on that ship, he already seemed to know some things. As a great explorer, he already had some sense of his fate. Our appearance only surprised him for a few seconds. After that, until the Window Interval ended, he only asked us some questions about how to sail in the border seas.”

A slight tremor and creaking sound reached Duncan’s ears. A low and uneasy noise echoed from the depths of the Vanished’s cabins. But after a few seconds, these strange sounds slowly faded.

Critt looked up at the dark roof above. Only after the surroundings became quiet again did he turn his gaze back to Duncan.

“After we missed that Window Interval, our only remaining chance to contact you was today. Or rather, only when the stability of the Sanctuary World dropped to its limit could beings like us, who go against order, safely enter your sight. And it is also because the stability of the Sanctuary World has dropped to the limit that we now have a chance to show you… a few things. This will help you understand the fate of this world, the fate that is ‘fixed’ so far.”

“Show me a few things?” Duncan’s expression became serious at once when he heard this. “What do you mean? What are you going to show me?”

“Before that, I want to confirm one thing.” Critt raised his head and stared at Duncan. “You have already turned down our Creator, have you not?”

“Your Creator… you mean Navigator One?” Duncan understood and then nodded. “Yes. He wanted me to take over his divine authority and take over this world. But I refused.”

“I see. That is good.” Hearing Duncan’s answer, Critt spoke as if talking to himself.

Duncan became a bit curious: “What does that have to do with what you are going to show me?”

Critt did not answer directly. Instead, he walked forward until he stood before the door that led to Subspace, which was tightly shut at this moment.

“Have you opened this door?”

“No.” Duncan walked over, and his voice turned wary at once. “This door leads to Subspace. Opening it in the Mortal Realm is not a good idea.”

“It is all right. There is no need to be nervous. I will not open it, and I do not have the power to open it.” Critt noticed the change in Duncan’s tone. A faint smile appeared on his face. “I am only bringing you to take a look.”

Duncan watched Critt’s movements and spoke in a careful tone: “Take a look?”

“Subspace reflects everything. As long as it is a possibility of this Sanctuary World, its answer has already been branded in that endless sea of chaos. And we…”

Critt muttered softly, then suddenly reached out and patted the doorframe twice.

“…we have always been good at fishing flickers from the long river of time out of that chaos.”

In the next second, under Duncan’s slightly surprised gaze, the big door suddenly shattered with a roar like an illusion. Lights beyond the limits of human understanding rushed at him like a storm and then, in a blink, re-formed around him.

Duncan almost struck out, but at the last possible moment he held back that impulse and instead chose to stand still and stay calm.

He felt no threat or hostility at all. He could even clearly feel that the door still stood intact in its place. Critt’s presence was also close by, with no change.

He looked around and found himself standing on a dark mountain peak. A dim and muddy sky hung over everything. A patch of dull light hid deep in the clouds. Below the mountain stretched a vast plain. In that boundless land, he could faintly see ruins like cities and also high aqueducts that had dried up and broken.

Other than that, there was only cracked, dried earth. A fine “gray” covered everything within sight, filled the ruins and channels, and rose with the wind in the valleys, blowing toward the plains like a drifting mist.

A biting cold filled the world, as if even the ashes thrown up by the wind were about to freeze.

Duncan quietly watched all of this. After a long time, he spoke in a low voice: “What is this?”

“This is the Age of Fire, Captain.” Critt’s voice came from the side. At some unknown time he had already appeared there. He still wore the same tattered white robe, but the robe now seemed even more ragged.

After a brief silence, Duncan asked again: “Is this some kind of History Branch?”

“This is the only History Branch under which the Sanctuary World continued to exist.” Critt spoke.

The “Ender” then paused, as if choosing his words, and went on:

“At the start, you reshaped the earth. All the grand plans on the Blueprint that had never been carried out appeared in the mortal world. Lands that humans had never imagined rose from the sea. City-states became linked. Resources became abundant. After that, you calmed the sea. You made more life grow in the sea, and you had the seawater purified among the mountains so it turned into rain and snow that fell upon the land.

“Then the world began to prosper. For a time, this New World grew even more lush than all the poems that praised beauty in the era of the Deep Sea. Strong nations rose upon the earth and grew day and night. New technologies were discovered. New poetry, literature, and dreams of the future appeared. Steam trains crossed forests and wild plains. Huge pipeline systems linked factories and the steel jungles of the cities.

“Countless stories, countless lives. Heroes and leaders, knights and philosophers, legendary adventurers, and ordinary people who worked hard in the cities.

“Captain, trust me. If I did not show you this moment, but instead showed you those glorious days, even you would feel a bit shaken. Even the strongest-willed governor and guardian in this world would be willing to trade everything for that world, even if its glory lasted… a very short time.”

Duncan did not speak. He stood on the mountain top and quietly looked down at the dry, broken land at his feet. After a long time, he broke the silence: “Were there still living people at this moment?”

“No. The ashes have swallowed everything. Do you see that city ruin? The tallest Cathedral at the center of the city… the last refugees died there. Now

there is only an empty soul wandering inside that Cathedral. She holds a greatsword in her hand, but at this moment that sword cannot protect anyone.”

Duncan raised his head again and looked at that patch of dim light in the sky: “And what is that?”

“A very small Sun. When the world began to cool, she tried to heat this land again and held on for a very long time.”

“And my flame?”

“It went out, Captain,” Critt said slowly. “After you burned everything in the world that could burn.”

Chapter 751: Veil of night

In the Future of Fire, the world had been burned out.

Flames were not eternal. Fuel inside the Sanctuary World also had a limit. Outside the reshaped land and ocean, that eternal Veil still bound the whole world. When everything inside the Veil turned to ash in the fire, the world ended in a long cooling.

It was said that this “cooling” lasted a full four hundred years. In the end, the age of Embers came. Cold ash covered the entire world. No new flames rose. No living thing cried or breathed. The world stopped in this pile of cold embers. No new things were born, and no old things faded away.

In a sense, this Sanctuary World, which had gone through the Great Annihilation, finally reached eternal peace. Embers were still Embers. Doomsday was frozen forever in this moment. No new suffering would ever fall upon this land again.

Duncan walked to a big stone and sat down without a care. He did not mind the ashes that were everywhere. He watched the city ruins on the plain that still kept crumbling and turning into ash. After a moment of thought, he suddenly spoke: “So this choice has no way back.”

“You can reshape everything,” Critt came to Duncan’s side. His thin, bent body stood in the cold wind like a crooked dead branch. “But there is one exception.”

“Myself,” Duncan understood and spoke softly. “I cannot redefine myself…”

Critt stayed silent. After a long time, he finally spoke: “If there truly were no other road, the Future of Flame would at least be a kind of continuation. But I hope you will think and think again. Time is like a river. Many of its branches can be changed. But the main stream that has already crossed the finish, once it has flowed past, can never turn back.”

“You do not have to worry about that. When I refused Navigator One’s plan, I had already thought through these things.” Duncan shook his head lightly. “What you have shown me only makes my earlier guesses more complete. Compared to that, my real gain is that I finally confirmed one thing…”

As he spoke, he raised his hand and slowly closed his fingers in the air. The ghostly green flame of the spirit form burned between his fingers at once. It swelled and jumped in the air like an illusion.

The world of ashes seemed to respond to this bit of flame. The wind on the mountaintop suddenly became restless, and even the nearby ashes showed strange waves. But it was only a momentary illusion. In the next second, the wind and the ashes went back to normal.

In this already ended History Branch, nothing could push it to move forward again.

Duncan quietly cast his gaze at the flame in his hand, then turned his palm over.

The spirit form fire went out at once. The silent, shattering flames turned into tiny sparks and flashed for a brief moment at his fingertips. For that instant, they looked like phantom starlight from a far-off place.

Duncan watched this scene with a grave look and seemed to be thinking: “These ‘fires’ really are only a surface.”

Then he turned his head and looked at Critt, who still stood quietly at his side: “You can see this History Branch. Can you see my other choices?”

“I am very sorry. I cannot.” Critt met Duncan’s gaze honestly. “We are ghosts trapped inside the time cycle of the Sanctuary World. We can only see everything inside this time loop. All your other choices lie outside the cycle. To us, they are like the huge Great Hollow in the veil of night, and my eyes cannot cross that vast darkness.”

“Outside the cycle… in other words, outside the Sanctuary World, this ‘Known World’?” Duncan reacted at once. “So in the end I still have to find a way to break through that eternal Veil?”

“I am sorry. I do not know.”

“Is that so.” Duncan nodded slowly and suddenly sounded a bit wistful. “Right now, I am actually a little jealous of Duncan Abnomar from a century ago. You showed him the future. It was an accident, but at least he knew where he should go.”

“Feeling around in the dark is suffering. Knowing your fate is also suffering. At the end of time, there is never any peace. I am sorry. We do not have good news. We did not have any from the day we set out.”

“It is fine. I was not expecting good news. As long as I gain some insight this time, that is enough.” Duncan got up from the big stone. No ash clung to him. “Time to leave.”

He gave the sky and land here one last look. His gaze swept over the faint sunlight behind the clouds and the tall-spired Cathedral in the city ruins. He did not ask Critt about anyone else’s future or where they were now. He simply turned away without any regret.

The History Branch behind him collapsed with a roar, like the great fire in Pland.

Light and shadow twisted and re-formed. Things went back to their places. The dim, closed cabin appeared again in Duncan's sight. The door that led to Subspace still stood quietly at the bottom of the hold. It was as if nothing had happened here.

Critt was still standing by the door, his hand still raised as if he had just patted the doorframe.

Then he lowered his hand and bowed slightly to Duncan: "I hope this did not trouble you."

"It is fine. I already have enough things to trouble me. One more does not make a difference." Duncan spoke lightly. "At least now we have confirmed that one of the roads is very bad."

"The Sanctuary World is broken beyond repair. There is no point in patching it up, though I should not say that." Critt sighed. "Its destruction is already set. Doomsday has been chasing this world down the river of time since the Great Annihilation. Now it has finally caught up."

"A Doomsday theory. That is the doctrine the Enders have always preached. People always thought it was just the raving of madmen after they went insane."

"Madness and reason are only one step apart. 'Truth' never cares about the gap between them." Critt's expression was calm. "From another point of view, my companions have never truly gone mad. They were just… tired. So they chose to embrace all the truth and became madmen in everyone's eyes."

"Will you turn into that as well?" Duncan suddenly grew curious. "In some time branch, or in the near future…"

"I do not know." Critt hesitated, then slowly shook his head. "dusk has come, but this world will not go dark all at once. I still have a little way left

on my journey. To speak with you within this Window Interval, I had to cut out the most stable ‘part’ of myself to come here. So now I do not know what the self at the end of my journey has seen. Maybe…”

He paused briefly and then went on: “Maybe one day in the future, we will meet again. The one who stands before you then might be a crazed, broken madman or a twisted, formless monster. That will mean I have reached the end and wandered too long in the dark. It is also possible…”

Critt suddenly stopped.

Then his eyes changed a little, as if he had suddenly seen a direction after a long time in darkness, as if he had just thought of something. The deep wrinkles on his face eased, and he looked at Duncan: “Right… I will do everything I can to meet you again, whether I am clear-headed or mad. I will show up before you. At that time, there will likely be no suitable Window Interval, so I probably will not be able to talk with you directly like I do now. You might not even be able to see me… but I will surely find a way to leave something behind. You can…”

The old man’s voice cut off.

In the dim, empty cabin, only Duncan’s lone figure stood quietly before the Subspace door.

He stood there like a statue for a long time. At last, he turned, picked up the brass consecrated lantern hanging not far away, and slowly walked toward the exit of the lower deck.

…

Now it was twelve hours after nightfall.

Just as the scholars had warned, the Sun had not risen. No dawn light appeared on the sea’s horizon.

If some people had still held onto hope before this, still praying that the seventy-two-hour dusk earlier had only been a “single abnormal event” and that the next morning the sun would rise on time, then that hope had now gone out completely.

The endless Long Night had become a fact.

Near Lightwind Harbor, the four great ark-ships still lay moored close to the shore. On the eastern offshore waters, the “glowing geometric body” continued to shed soft pale gold “sunlight,” so the city-state did not fall into full darkness.

The Academy Ark was lit up from end to end.

Short and stout Rune stood in the “Temple of Knowledge” at the very top of the ark, praying devoutly before the holy statue of Rahm, the God of Wisdom.

A chant made of “0” and “1,” with a very strange rhythm and sound, was slowly reaching its end.

Incense smoke rose through the temple. Rahm’s statue stood silent in the haze. The statue did not have a human form. It was a black rectangular stone stele. On its top was carved the rune of the Eye of Wisdom, and the whole stele was covered in dense symbols and fine lines.

As Rune’s benediction went on, those symbols and lines showed faint, slow flickers, as if they had been given life for a moment.

But as the benediction ended, the stele’s brief “life” faded with it.

Rune turned his head and looked at a Truth priest who had been waiting at his side the whole time: “How are things now?”

“The bad news is that the Sun still has not risen. The veil of night really seems likely to last a long time. The good news is that, based on data from

all the city-states, the drop in temperature is slowing down. Going by the current cooling curve, it seems the lowest temperatures each city-state will reach during this veil of night will not go below the record lows in history. The world will not freeze solid in this Long Night the way you feared… the ‘Cold calamity’ will not happen.”

As the priest gave his report, some tension left Rune’s face at last. But soon he frowned again: “…Is that really good news?”

Chapter 752: On the Road to the Apocalypse

(Translation Changes here from Bcat00 to Novelfire for the rest of the Novel)

The Pope’s reaction seemed to confuse the priest standing next to him, prompting him to begin with a note of caution. “Surely, the fact that the world hasn’t plunged into eternal winter despite the sun being absent for an extended period is a piece of good news, isn’t it?”

“Yes, if we consider only this aspect, it indeed is good news,” Lune, the Truth Pope, responded with a gentle shake of his head. “However, what does this say about the sun’s supposed influence? What about our fundamental understanding of the world, in terms of the ‘rules that are meant to be obeyed’?”

The priest, a man in his middle years, furrowed his brow slightly as he began to grasp the depth of the Pope’s concern.

“The sun is essential for providing light and warmth. Its rising heralds a gradual increase in temperature during the day, and its setting brings about the cool of the night. If the sun were absent for a significant period, we would expect the Boundless Seas to turn to ice. This follows the natural order as clearly as ice melting when exposed to fire. But now, it appears that the night’s temperature drop doesn’t depend on the sun,” Lune explained with a serious tone. “Do you understand the implication?”

Without waiting for the priest's response, Lune continued after a short pause. "It's as if we're dealing with a machine that's been taken over by malevolent forces—a spinning axle that doesn't stop even when the steam core has gone cold, a different engine that continues to produce paper tape despite its gears being stuck. The way things work and their expected outcomes are increasingly at odds. It seems some of the natural laws… are breaking down."

A heavy silence enveloped the temple for a moment until the middle-aged priest broke it. "Perhaps we should reach out to the other three Arks…"

"They're already observing these anomalies; they probably don't need our warning," Lune interjected. "What's more crucial… has our border fleet set sail yet?"

The priest nodded immediately, "Yes, they passed through the veil an hour ago, and we are still communicating with them. The fleets from the other three churches have also entered the border from various directions. So far, there have been no incidents."

Lune nodded slowly, "…And what about the evacuation routes at sea?"

"We've established twenty-six rally points along the primary maritime routes, centrally positioning large church ships and supply vessels at each. Numerous ships that couldn't make it back to the city-states in time have heeded our call and are now converging on these rally points for safety. According to our plans, these refuge ships will then be led to a 'safe distance,' a three-day sail away from the nearest city-state, where they'll remain until the end of the night."

"The true effectiveness of these makeshift 'night shelters' at sea remains uncertain. We have no way of predicting how the night might evolve over time. For now, our only option is to prepare as thoroughly as we can and brace ourselves for the possibility of the worst-case scenario unfolding…"

Lune listened in silence, nodding in understanding.

Suddenly, a series of bells rang out, cutting through their conversation—a sound that came from various sectors of the Ark, each ring infused with a palpable sense of urgency.

Caught off guard, Lune paused, then, as if a realization dawned on him, he listened more closely. A faint smile broke across his face as he said, "… They've returned."

Against the backdrop of the night-covered seas, the Vanished and the Bright Star made their presence known with their eerie green fires, appearing as beacons in the darkness. These two ghostly ships bypassed the warning lines set by the church and city-state fleets near the shore, making a beeline for Wind Harbor. Having been instructed beforehand, the patrolling fleets made no move to intercept them.

With no effort to hide or delay, the Vanished and the Bright Star made landfall on the eastern coast of Wind Harbor. Duncan, taking the lead, walked confidently into the city.

Nina, gripping Shirley's hand, trailed behind Duncan and Morris. They navigated the deserted streets of the port area with furrowed brows.

"…The last time we were here, it was bustling with life…"

"Now, it's only patrolled by guards," Shirley responded quietly. She had blindfolded herself with a strip of black cloth to hide her unsettling eyes, but she quickly realized that such precautions were perhaps unnecessary. Upon entering the city, they scarcely encountered anyone, "I've heard the martial law could last a month or two."

Under martial law, the city-state of Wind Harbor should have been teeming with activity by morning. Yet, aside from essential personnel and those in special positions, the majority of residents were adhering to directives to

remain indoors. The dim, golden “sunlight” emanating from the sea cast a ghostly glow on the abandoned streets, evoking the atmosphere of a ghost town.

In contrast, the city’s other half, untouched by the glowing body’s “sunlight,” was engulfed in an even more oppressive darkness.

However, as they moved from the outskirts to the more populated areas of the city, they began to encounter the occasional hurried pedestrian and saw a few shops bravely opening their doors.

“Shops are actually open here!” Shirley expressed her surprise upon “seeing” a few open storefronts along the way, “And there are people walking around…”

“You’ve mentioned it yourself; martial law is expected to span a month or two. During this period, some semblance of normalcy in daily life has to be preserved,” Morris explained, shaking his head. “It’s likely that each city-state has come up with a sort of ‘daily routine’ tailored to the prolonged night, permitting people to leave their homes for shopping or work despite the martial law… Life has to continue, after all.”

While Shirley and Morris exchanged thoughts, Duncan remained silent, his attention fixed on the deserted street ahead. Without joining the conversation, he simply stated, “We’ve seen what we needed to… Ai.”

Suddenly, a flame appeared out of thin air, and a fiery skeletal giant bird began to circle overhead, emitting a piercing screech: “Who summons the fleet?”

“Take us to 99 Crown Street,” Duncan instructed.

A trail of fire blazed through the sky above Wind Harbor, resembling a shooting star. It traversed the city part bathed in the artificial “sunlight”

from the sea and headed directly towards the “Witch’s Mansion” in the upper city district.

This fiery spectacle caught the eye of many onlookers, but to those in the know, it was a sign of reassuring… good news.

Upon the flame’s descent, the scene before them came into focus, revealing Lucretia facing the unexpected visitors at her doorstep.

Among them were Helena, commanding presence in her sea-blue robe, Lune, somewhat stout in a scholar’s robe, and a group of unrecognizable clerics and scholars, appearing as attendants or aides accompanying the two high-ranking church figures.

It seemed they had been waiting there for some time.

“…Wow,” Nina whispered under her breath, observing the gathering, “Quite a crowd has shown up…”

“It’s not that surprising,” Duncan remarked, his tone nonchalant.

Lucretia’s initial response was a frown. She scrutinized the “guests” who had been waiting at her entrance and stepped forward without concealing her irritation, “I’m not fond of having visitors, especially not this many.”

However, Lune didn’t take offense to the “Sea Witch’s” forthright demeanor. It appeared he was well-acquainted with Miss Witch’s personality and quirks, and he gestured for his group to depart: “Then the rest of you may return now.”

Following suit, Helena signaled for her own clerics and guards to leave, then nodded towards Lucretia, “Now, you only have two ‘guests’ to entertain.”

With a glance at the two high clerics at her threshold, Lucretia exhaled a resigned sigh and moved aside, “…Fine, my father indeed wished to speak

with you. Luni, please, open the door."

The mechanical doll Luni immediately moved past the group to unlock the door, while Duncan gave a slight nod to Lune and Helena, "Let's discuss this inside."

The mansion was a beacon of light and warmth in the midst of the night's darkness. The chill that had settled outside was no match for the cozy fireplace within. Loyal to the mansion's mistress, mechanical dolls and tin servants had meticulously prepared the house for her return. The table now bore hot tea and freshly baked snacks, their warmth a testament to the oven's recent use.

Inside this illuminated and inviting space, the outside world's perpetual, unsettling night and its unraveling seams could easily be forgotten.

The living room became the setting for their gathering, with Duncan adopting a relaxed posture on the sofa. He acknowledged Helena and Lune, who were seated opposite him, with a nod, expressing his surprise at their personal presence. "I hadn't anticipated you would wait here for me. I was under the impression that leaving the 'Ark' was a matter of great seriousness and caution for individuals of your stature."

"Indeed, without a compelling reason, we would not venture from the Ark lightly. However, convening with you at the earliest opportunity constitutes such a reason," Helena responded, acknowledging the gravity of their meeting, "particularly in light of the current situation."

"What is it that you seek to understand now?" Duncan inquired, "Are you curious about the state of the world at present? The origins of this apocalypse? Or perhaps what the future holds?"

A moment of silent communication passed between Lune and Helena before they responded.

“We are eager to learn everything,” Lune declared, shifting in his seat to lean forward, his demeanor growing more earnest. “But foremost, we wish to hear about the occurrences on the Holy Island and your… interactions with the creator of this world.”

Helena chimed in, mentioning that they had received preliminary reports from the Tide, “But we suspect you possess a deeper knowledge of the truth.”

After a brief reflection, Duncan gave a slight nod.

“Then, let me start by presenting a fundamental premise,” he began, preparing them for what was to come.

At the mention of a ‘conclusion,’ a sense of foreboding enveloped Helena, “A conclusion?”

“Yes, a conclusion—the fate of our world is sealed. The possibility of mending is exhausted, and at best… any efforts can only delay the inevitable for a brief period.”

Duncan’s delivery was calm, his voice not raised, yet each word seemed imbued with an immense gravity.

Chapter 753: Another Plan

Everyone looks forward to receiving good news, but, unfortunately, as Crete conveyed to Duncan, there simply isn't any positive news to share when it comes to the end of time.

They found themselves in a modest sanctuary, created from the remnants of destruction, now rapidly hurdling towards its inevitable demise. This impending doom wasn't the result of anyone's mistake, nor could it be attributed to a specific flaw in their plan or an act of human treachery. It was the culmination of everything coming to an end as the era of the apocalypse had arrived.

Lune and Helena listened in somber silence as Duncan recounted everything to them. He shared insights from the exploratory team's ventures into the border waters, the discoveries made on the Holy Island, his unsettling encounter with the Nether Lord, and even his audacious scheme to "conquer the world."

Duncan chose not to keep this last detail a secret. He seemed unconcerned about revealing to the two Popes before him that there existed "another option" for saving the world. Similarly, he didn't shy away from discussing the grim future foretold by the "future of fire," nor did he conceal the ultimate demise of everything, as revealed to him by the Ender.

Lune and Helena remained quiet for what seemed like an eternity, even after Duncan had finished sharing all he knew. They didn't utter a single word for a long time.

After a period of reflective silence, Lune finally let out a gentle sigh, remarking, "Some truths are perhaps better left undiscovered."

"To those unburdened by knowledge, ignorance is a luxury, but you, unfortunately, do not have that luxury," Duncan responded calmly. "Given all that you now know, what are your thoughts?"

After pondering for a moment, Helena slowly lifted her head, her gaze firm and said, “Despite the seemingly inevitable end of the world, it doesn’t mean that all other paths are closed to us, does it?”

She paused, locking eyes with Duncan, her deep blue eyes, as vast and mysterious as the ocean, seemed to mirror the distant, churning waves: “You have another plan in mind, don’t you?”

Standing nearby, Vanna’s eyes widened in surprise. As the Pope spoke, she thought she could hear the soft, distant sound of the ocean, though it felt almost like an illusion, a fleeting glimpse from a goddess paying them no mind.

Suddenly, Vanna came to a realization and turned towards Duncan, about to speak, but Duncan raised his hand to stop her, then calmly met the intense gaze of the “Storm Pope”: “Hello.”

The “female Pope” seemed to ignore his greeting, her focus unyielding on Duncan, a storm of emotions swirling in her eyes. She repeated, “You do have another plan, don’t you?”

Her voice carried a slight tremble, echoing as if surrounded by a chorus of indistinct whispers, transforming the atmosphere in the room to one that was moist, chilly, and tinged with the unique, salty scent of the sea breeze.

Shirley and Dog could feel the shift in the air, an unease settling over them as the atmosphere in the room changed.

Duncan, unfazed by the tension, exhaled softly and responded with calm certainty, “…Create a new one.”

The “female Pope” merely frowned slightly, offering no verbal response.

“The Boundless Sea sanctuary is beyond repair. Any attempts to patch it up are futile; they merely delay the inevitable struggle for survival. Initiating the age of fire is another way to survive, but it’s a path of no return. Choosing this means sealing the fate of our entire civilization in a tomb…”

Duncan’s words were deliberate, his gaze fixed on the “female Pope” as he spoke, then he made a decisive cutting motion with his hand.

“If the effort to prolong the existence of our old world is destined to fail or proves to be unreliable, then we are left with only one option… Not to extend the life of the old world, but to forge a new one.”

The “female Pope” blinked, breaking her silence as the soft sound of waves seemed to rise around them. Her voice, trembling as if resonating directly with everyone’s soul, asked, “Another sanctuary?”

“Another world,” Duncan clarified calmly.

He paused, allowing a moment of silence to envelop the room, during which the crackling of the nearby fireplace became the most prominent sound.

“A sanctuary is a confined, limited system, where disaster safety nets are minimal, resources can only circulate within, and vital life-support systems are singular—there’s only one sun, only one Boundless Sea, and even the number of city-states was capped at its inception. All these elements are confined under the same unchanging sky…”

“This system’s inherent fragility becomes apparent in the face of a cataclysmic disaster. It’s like a building on the verge of collapse, with those inside unable to mend the entire structure, mere spectators to the gradual downfall of their sanctuary. No matter how long the sanctuary has stood or how many years the civilization within has flourished, their fate is already sealed.”

“The limit of any civilization’s development within the sanctuary is defined by that ‘shell’—the unchanging sky.”

Under the intense scrutiny of the “female Pope,” Duncan spread his arms wide, his expression gravely serious: “Hence, we require a world, a ‘world’ far larger than any sanctuary, capable of embracing endless possibilities, allowing civilization to evolve beyond its current confines. Ideally, even when faced with the apocalypse once more, this world would possess the

capacity to preserve more seeds of life, rather than plunging into oblivion as the last light of the sun fades away…”

The “female Pope” observed Duncan intently, and after a brief pause, she softly asked, “We understand the concept, but how can it actually be implemented? After the cataclysmic destruction, managing to sustain a sanctuary like the Boundless Sea amidst the fiery remnants of chaos is already a feat of near impossibility. Beyond our sanctuary, the concept of order has been shattered, and we have waited endlessly without ever glimpsing a sliver of hope for the chaos to subside… This Boundless Sea represents the last vestige of order, and beyond its confines, there is nothing left from which to construct a new refuge.”

As she spoke, the ambient sounds of waves subtly mixed with distant, unsettling noises. Helena’s eyes gradually took on a chaotic gleam, hinting at an internal turmoil. Something seemed to stir within her as delicate, deep purple scales reminiscent of some aquatic creature quietly surfaced on the skin of her cheeks.

Yet, she maintained her composure, sitting upright on the sofa, her gaze fixed on Duncan, awaiting his response.

Morris, Lucretia, and the others remained silent, fully aware that this was not the moment for interjections.

Duncan then addressed the core issue, “So, it boils down to ‘order,’ the foundational ‘order’ necessary for the sustenance of the entire world—the sanctuary’s finite existence is also a consequence of deficiencies in this order.”

Looking into the “female Pope’s” insightful eyes, Duncan seemed to connect with a distant realm beyond them, and then he exhaled softly, “… This aligns with my thoughts exactly.”

He gestured towards himself, affirming, “I carry that order, the complete ‘order.’”

The room lapsed into silence.

In that moment, Duncan felt a warm touch on his hand. Turning, he saw Nina clutching his palm, her expression tinged with concern.

Duncan offered her a reassuring smile, gently stroking her hair, “Don’t worry.”

Nina inhaled deeply, nodding with conviction—yet, from her perspective, Duncan’s comforting smile began to blur and dissolve into a myriad of stars.

That smile transitioned into a celestial spectacle as grand and luminous as the Milky Way itself. A figure constructed from starlight gradually rose to dominate everyone’s field of vision. This cosmic entity, composed of ancient stars, nebulae, and regions of star formation, seemed to envelop everything in sight. Despite standing within the confines of the living room, it appeared vast enough to encompass the entire universe, bearing the weight of all creation.

The figure then leaned towards “Helena,” with the celestial illusion around it pulsing and quivering as if on the verge of a massive expansion, ready to unleash and transform into devouring starlight.

“The order of the entire universe—intact and uncorrupted, unaffected by the Great Annihilation,” Duncan declared, his voice resonating through the stellar expanse, “It exists briefly in a moment, yet from the standpoint of data, it is whole and complete.”

As Duncan immersed himself in the sensation of his own existence amidst the grandeur of the cosmos, he experienced what felt like a galactic-scale “breathing” for the very first time—a profound realization of his own cosmic essence expanding and contracting. Yet, almost immediately, he curbed the urge to indulge further in this cosmic respiration.

He was acutely aware that his transformation had been accelerating ever since he left the Holy Island. Initially, Duncan’s only glimpses of his altered self came from the fleeting, inadvertent looks from others. After encountering the Pale Giant King and uncovering a fragment of the truth, he began to observe the shimmer of starlight on his own reflection in mirrors.

More recently, he had noticed his transformations directly in his “bachelor apartment,” and now… he recognized the necessity of exerting control to maintain his human facade.

Time was running out for the sanctuary and for Duncan himself.

Looking into the “female Pope’s” eyes, Duncan perceived the vision of a distant entity—a creature long perished, lying coiled atop a grey-white stone within a palace-like nest, surrounded by numerous deceased “offspring.”

This ancient being lifted its head, its myriad eyes locking onto Duncan’s gaze.

Through Helena, the creature’s voice reached him: “…So beautiful…”

Addressing the current predicaments, Duncan, striving to rein in his celestial manifestation, stated, “Now we face two issues.” He forced the cosmic brilliance to recede, reverting to his “Duncan” persona. “First, ‘data’ alone is insufficient for constructing a new world; I require physical materials, and a vast quantity at that… Yet, I’m unsure of how to undertake this task. I only have a broad, intuitive sense that what I need cannot be found within this Boundless Sea—it’s simply too limited, not nearly adequate.”

“Second, it remains unclear to me how to safeguard everything within this sanctuary while ushering in a new world. In the moment of the new world’s inception, its dazzling emergence might cause everything here to dissipate like smoke.”

Chapter 754: Sunrise

In an awe-inspiring spectacle, countless stars seemed to cascade from the heavens, their distant and brilliant lights gradually coalescing into a human form. This was Duncan, transitioning from the ethereal glow of starlight to a realm that both Vanna and Morris could grasp. However, Duncan's voice retained an otherworldly quality, resonating as if from a higher dimension. The complex overlay of whispers and noise, intertwining reason with cognition, overwhelmed Vanna, rendering her nearly incapable of coherent thought.

Time became an elusive concept, blurring into what felt like a mere instant. Eventually, Vanna senses the cacophony in her mind and begins to ebb. She caught Morris, with shaky hands, preparing his pipe, his voice barely audible as he remarked on becoming accustomed to such experiences.

"Incredible, it feels like I'm meeting the Nether Lord again," declared Dog, lying at Shirley's feet, convinced he had glimpsed the Nether Lord during the ordeal.

Nina appeared comparatively composed, momentarily stunned before she lapsed into deep contemplation. Now and then, she stole worried glances at Duncan.

Meanwhile, Duncan himself maintained a serene composure, locking eyes with "Helena." It was as if he was peering into the soul of this ancient being through her eyes, which mirrored the vastness of distant oceans.

After what seemed an eternity, a voice finally merged with the gentle lapping of waves, reaching everyone, “I understand… We will meet again.”

As the sound of waves faded, the damp, fishy scent that pervaded the air began to dissipate. Helena blinked, her inhuman traits vanishing rapidly before she doubled over, gasping and retching violently. Vanna was quick to her side, offering support and employing her divine magic to soothe Helena’s distress.

Once Helena’s breathing eased, she looked up, her face pallid yet adorned with a heartfelt smile. “It’s been ages since I’ve felt Her presence,” she whispered, “I had nearly forgotten the sensation…”

“Never mind your feelings, you were close to death. You need to return to the Ark immediately for mental recuperation,” Lune interjected, clearly concerned for her well-being. His attention then shifted to Duncan, suggesting it was time to depart.

Duncan signaled his readiness with a gesture.

Helena, now somewhat recovered, stood from the sofa. She and Lune bid Duncan farewell before embarking on their journey back to the Ark.

However, as she reached the threshold of the “Witch’s Mansion,” Helena paused, looking back at Duncan, who remained in the living room.

“Continue with your duties,” Duncan encouraged, sensing her hesitation, “Even as the world faces its end, we must persevere, if only to extend the lives of others by one more day.”

With a silent nod, Helena turned, stepping into the vast, dark night outside while accompanied by Lune.

As the popes departed and the door swung shut, it severed the connection with the expansive, dark night beyond. A blanket of silence swiftly enveloped the entire living room once more. Amidst the subtle crackle of

the fireplace, it appeared as though each person was lost in their own world of thoughts, their heads bowed in quiet reflection.

After what felt like an eternity of contemplation, Duncan shattered the silence with his sudden insight: “Considering we’ve merely been hosting a guest for a short period, and now one of the two popes has nearly met their demise—losing nearly half their life—do you think the Storm Church might suspect that we’ve laid a trap? Imagining that we’ve surrounded them with no less than five hundred armed attackers right within these walls?”

Lucretia, who had been deeply immersed in her own thoughts, was abruptly brought back to reality. She looked up, her eyes reflecting a mix of surprise and incredulity: “All this time in silence, and that’s what you’ve been brooding over?”

With a look of earnest concern, Duncan replied, “Isn’t it a valid concern?” He continued, addressing Lucretia directly, “Given the notoriety your household already endures within this city, with rumors abounding that you’ve been responsible for all manner of sinister deeds—ranging from cooking pots filled with children to ensnaring stray dogs from across the world…”

Lucretia responded with a sharp look, though her irritation soon gave way to resignation as she gazed back out the window, “Well then, I suppose I should be grateful for such rumors. Perhaps they’ll spare me from the weekly barrage of sales flyers in my mailbox.” She paused, then added with a hint of resignation, “…Though, I doubt I’ll be seeing any more of those flyers now.”

With a soft sigh, Duncan rose from his seat on the sofa. “I’ve spoken more than enough, and I find myself weary. I’ll retire to my room for some rest. Please don’t delay lunch on my account.”

As he ascended the stairs, which emitted a gentle creak with each step, Duncan's tall silhouette gradually vanished from view at the top.

The remaining individuals in the living room exchanged puzzled glances, momentarily unsure of how to proceed.

Shirley was the first to break the ensuing silence: "I must admit, I was kind of lost during their conversation just now," she confessed, "But one thing did make sense to me. The pope earlier… she wasn't the same one, was she?"

Vanna nodded slowly in agreement: "The Goddess has revealed to me that Their bond with this mortal realm is to be fortified one final time. It seems that process has already begun."

Unable to contain her curiosity, Nina posed the question in everyone's mind: "What happens next?"

Morris, cradling his pipe thoughtfully, responded with a somber tone, "In times past, optimists could confidently say 'the sun will rise as usual tomorrow.' Yet, even that assurance lacks its once comforting certainty." He added, "But come what may, tomorrow will arrive, regardless of whether the sun graces us with its presence. Just as the captain remarked, life must go on. He has his duties, and we have ours."

The tobacco in his pipe slowly smoldered away, its final embers fading into the lingering smoke.

A gentle breeze meandered through the living room, carrying with it a whirl of colorful confetti that danced briefly before vanishing from sight, leaving a sense of mystery and anticipation for what the future might hold.

As Duncan felt the breeze behind him, he was immediately aware of a familiar presence drawing near. Turning around, he witnessed Lucretia's form materializing from a swirl of vibrant confetti that danced in the air.

“I would’ve thought after the mishap we had last time, you’d refrain from making such a grand entrance with all these colorful papers in front of me,” Duncan remarked, a playful smile on his face, “Aren’t you concerned it might fuel my already keen curiosity?”

Without directly addressing his comment, Lucretia fixed her gaze on Duncan, her expression unreadable. “You’re planning to venture beyond the Eternal Veil, aren’t you? To cross the critical threshold of six miles?”

Duncan paused before responding, “Why do you ask?”

“It’s clear you’re in search of something beyond the Boundless Sea. Though the specifics of your conversation with that ‘pope’ elude me, I’m certain you’re preparing to traverse the veil once more. And this time, I sense you intend to journey farther and remain absent longer.”

Duncan took a moment to consider the “witch” standing before him. After a lengthy silence, he finally said, ” Lucy, you must have seen it for yourself by now.”

In that moment, the room seemed to be touched by a hint of starlight, casting Lucretia’s gaze into the depths of a distant cosmos.

“I see it,” the “Sea Witch” admitted openly, “Indeed, from the moment you first appeared before me, I’ve seen it.”

As the starlight dimmed, Duncan looked at the “witch,” taken aback by her admission. “Then you must understand, I’m not exactly…”

“It didn’t matter to Nina whether you were her ‘Uncle Duncan’ or not,” Lucretia interjected calmly.

Duncan let out a sigh, a mixture of resignation and bemusement on his face.

“Amid the starlight, I’ve glimpsed the silhouette of my father—regardless of your acknowledgment,” Lucretia continued, shaking her head slightly,

“It’s evident to me that you have indeed returned to our world, albeit through means beyond my comprehension. Yet here you are, standing before me as you do in my memories, and now, you’re preparing to leave once more… just as you did before.”

She then became more somber, “Do you recall our conversation on this matter?”

“…About taking you with me, yes, I remember,” Duncan acknowledged after a brief pause, “Alright, Lucy, I’ll confess, before you arrived, I did entertain the thought of departing alone—just for a moment, mind you, with no real intention of acting on it…”

Perhaps it was the intensity of the witch’s unwavering gaze that compelled him, but Duncan found himself adding, somewhat awkwardly, “I only considered it briefly, truly…”

To his surprise, however, a faint smile began to form in Lucretia’s eyes.

Unable to contain herself any longer, Lucretia burst into laughter, her joy evident.

Duncan, puzzled, asked, “What’s so funny?”

“You used to get so flustered trying to explain things to me, though it happened only rarely,” Lucretia managed to say through her laughter, “The last time was when you accidentally broke my hairpin.”

Duncan stood there, a picture of bewilderment, his hands outstretched in a gesture of utter helplessness.

Suddenly, a brilliant streak of light outside the window cut through the air, abruptly halting whatever he was about to say next.

Without hesitation, Duncan and Lucretia hurried to the window to get a better look.

Bathed in the thin, golden glow cast by a glowing geometric object in the sky, a more intense arc of light began to emerge on the distant horizon of the city.

Duncan gazed at the emerging “light arc” with a mix of confusion and dawning realization.

From the vantage point of Pland’s antique shop, his view through the open window on the second floor offered a clearer picture—a radiant, golden light was gradually ascending from the horizon, its brilliance unmatched.

In those first few moments of awe and wonder, almost everyone was convinced they were witnessing the dawn.

However, as the golden arc rose fully above the sea and started to ascend into the sky with breathtaking speed, its fragmented nature became increasingly apparent. The structure began to disintegrate further as it climbed higher.

Finally, Duncan now had a full grasp of what was truly happening.

What he was seeing was a fragment of a ring structure, apparently a section of the outer rune circle belonging to Vision 001. The bright edge of the arc was marred by visible black cracks, leading to the eventual fragmentation of the entire “light arc” into a dozen or so loosely connected glowing pieces. Within mere minutes, this disintegrating “glowing array” had ascended to a position in the sky comparable to that of the sun around nine or ten o’clock.

Then, the isolated segment of the rune circle that had ascended into the heavens fell apart completely.

With a world-shattering roar accompanied by a fearsome howl and a blinding flash that ripped through the sky, the glowing array transformed

into a dozen “meteors.” These fiery trails streaked across the sky, hurtling down toward the unsuspecting people below.

Chapter 755: Crossing the Border

This event was akin to witnessing a magnificent burst of light, almost as if one-fourth of what could be described as a magical circle of solar energy had suddenly fragmented in the heavens. This fragmentation then transformed into about a dozen radiant, larger formations. In the moments following this initial breakup, these formations seemed to continue their ascent and movement across the sky, mirroring the expected path of Vision 001. It appeared as though each of these luminous entities retained some form of residual energy and directionality. However, this semblance of control was fleeting.

Soon after, these radiant formations began to deteriorate, breaking into both large and small shards of light that scattered across the sky. This spectacle resembled a fleet being torn asunder by a tempest, leaving behind bright trails that slowly dissipated. Among the chaos, numerous smaller light particles detached from the larger masses. These smaller fragments, akin to fireflies in their inconspicuousness compared to the larger pieces, descended from the heavens in a dance of flickers and a cascade of minor explosions.

From the clouds, light poured forth, spanning from the eastern frontier to the western isles, casting the night into a surreal glow of potent, otherworldly golden light.

The descent of the larger fragments was marked by a gradual pace, continuously releasing glowing debris as they traversed the world. Their paths were predominantly directed towards the southwestern seas, although

a handful of smaller pieces ventured towards the central and northern territories.

Eighteen hours into what was considered “nightfall,” the Boundless Sea was momentarily bathed in light, reminiscent of a significant solar disintegration. The relatively low altitude at which these objects descended meant that even a fraction of the magical solar circle was sufficient to illuminate the night sky. What might have been seen as a harbinger of doom —a “meteor shower”—instead bestowed upon the world a fleeting period of “daylight” lasting nearly an hour. During this transient day, an eerie silence enveloped the world.

Duncan found himself observing this vision from the second-floor window of an antique shop. He had opened a slender window at the corridor’s end, inviting the outside breeze and sounds into the building. The surrounding neighborhood lay in quietude as if the usual city noises of carriages and pedestrians had vanished into thin air. Yet, the reality was different.

Individuals of all ages—men, women, the elderly, and children—either stepped out of their homes or peered through their windows, captivated by the celestial spectacle. On the streets, groups formed, comprising quickly mobilized sheriffs and guardian squads.

It was as though an unseen force had seized everyone by the neck, holding them in a uniform stance, their gazes locked skyward, mesmerized by the cascading light.

Amidst this silence, the only audible sounds were the roar and whistle of the glowing entities as they streaked through the clouds, accompanied by the distant tolling of church bells.

After an indeterminate span of time, the brilliance in the sky began to wane —the final glowing entities made their way past the zenith amidst the clouds. For a moment, they lingered aloft as if striving to fulfill their

destined role to cast light upon the world, yet ultimately, they too succumbed to a loss of energy. Like their predecessors, they descended towards the ocean, their once resplendent trails dimming into obscurity.

Darkness reclaimed its hold, enveloping Pland once more.

The entire world was plunged back into shadow.

A whistle pierced the quiet of the neighborhood, startling the gathered crowds out of their reverie. Stirred by the sound, people began to disperse in an organized manner, heading back to their homes.

Before Duncan closed the window, other sounds reached him—children's voices filled with confusion and curiosity, questioning their parents about the night's events, wondering why their routines were disrupted, why they could no longer meet with friends. Murmurs of frustration, sighs of resignation, and the soft sounds of weeping filled the air.

The last noises to drift in from outside were the foghorns from the dock's direction and the ringing of church bells, signaling that warships had received orders and were making ready to depart.

Frem redirected his attention from the window back to his task, his hands moving with deliberate precision as he etched the final symbols into a ritual stone tablet.

Bathed in the light, the figure of this Pope of the Flame Bearers stood in stark relief, a silhouette poised between illumination and shadow. His face, reminiscent of carved stone, betrayed no hint of emotion, his entire focus seemingly absorbed by the "record stone tablet" he manipulated.

Inside the temple, the fire blazed intensely. A priest garbed in black stood nearby, delivering an update to the pope: "…The patrol fleet stationed in the southwestern seas has observed the trajectory of several primary luminous fragments and has dispatched high-speed vessels to investigate…

“Currently, there have been no reports of these objects making landfall near any city-states. It appears that the remnants of the sun have all plummeted into the ocean… Likewise, there are no accounts of sea vessels encountering these descending fragments.”

“The World’s Creation has once again become visible in the heavens… Over the last eighteen hours, three city-states have reported a marked rise in incidents of supernatural corrosion within their confines… For the moment, they do not seek additional support, though they request that the nearest fleet draw closer…”

“A shadow demon assault occurred in the Port of Mosalara. It remains uncertain whether this attack stems from the recent event or if it signifies an opportunistic strike by the remaining Annihilators amid the turmoil…”

As Frem attentively absorbed the series of updates from the priest, he gave a small nod of acknowledgment before handing over the newly finished, grey-white stone tablet: “I’ve documented everything—ensure this gets to our archives.”

The priest clad in black robes accepted the stone tablet, its surface etched with meticulous carvings that chronicled the dates and observations of the sun fragments’ descent.

The act stirred a memory of a doctrine from their holy texts within him—even at the brink of the world’s end, it is imperative to meticulously document until the final moment. The last whisper of civilization should be captured by the historian’s pen.

With the record stone tablet in hand, the priest departed, leaving Frem standing alone for company, with only the sound of the fire crackling in the basin.

Time passed unmarked until Frem seemed to perceive something unseen and turned towards the fire basin: “Helena, how fares your recovery?”

“My mental state could perhaps be likened to that of the living, yet far from truly ‘recovered’,” came Helena’s voice from the flames, her tone wavering slightly, revealing her unrest to Frem, “Clearly, resting idly is not an option at this stage.”

Frem responded, informed by a prior conversation: “I’ve been briefed by Lune. The news is… profoundly unsettling.”

“Does your concern lie with the divine intervention I received, or is it the ‘captain’s’ strategy?”

“…Both,” Frem admitted after a pause, his voice carrying a weight of contemplation, “Naturally, the latter presents the greater shock.”

A brief silence ensued before the voice from the fire resumed.

“Frem.”

“I am listening.”

“…Do you continue to document our history?”

“Without cease, I fulfill the scriptural command to chronicle our times.”

“Should the world meet its demise and we with it, do you think the stone tablets you’ve inscribed will one day be deciphered by future beings?”

“If such a day were to dawn, it would signify the collapse of the captain’s strategy, the deities’ defeat, and the extinguishment of the era of fire,” Frem spoke softly, his gaze fixed on the dancing flames, “Our histories would become indecipherable, for on that day, the very notion of ‘history’ would cease to exist.”

“Yet, you persist in your recordings and in safeguarding the beacon of legacy.”

“The act of recording history holds intrinsic value. Even absent future inheritors, ‘history’ itself stands as testament that we existed as a civilization unto extinction—echoing the final verses of the deranged poet Puman:

‘Time bestowed upon me life, and in return, I endowed time with memories.’”

“I hadn’t pegged you for a connoisseur of poetry.”

“Poetry is intertwined with history.”

“Is that so?” The voice from the fire hesitated briefly, then pressed on, “In that case, assist me in documenting a new entry—when next you pray to the Eternal Flame, etch it upon a stone.”

Without hesitation, Frem reached for a parchment and readied his pen: “Proceed.”

“…On the 21st of the first month, 1902, according to the New City-State Calendar, the Sea Song embarked on a momentous journey across the critical boundary of the six miles notch at the Eternal Veil. They stand at the forefront of our civilization’s exploration.”

“The Sea Song, 21st of the first month, 1902… Got it, it’s been recorded.”

…

The fog had morphed into an almost sentient entity, far from the simple, drifting mist it once seemed. The steamship, ‘The Sea Song,’ labored through the fog that seemed to swallow the world whole, its progress hindered as if pushing through a dense, invisible barrier, ensnared and constrained by unseen forces.

Within this heavy shroud, the usual demarcations of the world blurred into obscurity—the waters beside the ship transformed into a nebulous mass of gray-white, the sky above shed its clouds for a uniform haze, and a diffuse daylight cast everything in a vague glow. Only sporadically could the lookout discern the undulating seawater through the fog's fleeting breaches.

These glimpses of water, distant and ephemeral, were like visual illusions.

Adorned with the Storm Church's flag, the white vessel, a pioneer of exploration, seemed suspended in the fog. Despite the steam core's persistent thrum, the absence of fixed points and the ever-shifting fog rendered the crew unable to ascertain their advancement—or if they were ensnared in this anomalous "sea".

"We've lost all signals from the flagship, and at present, we could barely catch the beacon from the temporary lighthouse," reported a church sailor clad in a dark blue cloak to the 'The Sea Song's captain on the bridge, "The steam core is at maximum output, and we're holding our course."

"Mm," the captain, a formidable woman with an aura of stern resolve, acknowledged the sailor's update. She then directed her attention to an adjacent priest: "In this direction, can you discern anything more distinctly?"

She inquired of an aged priest garbed in a flowing robe, his face lined with deep wrinkles, eyes recessed, and posture stooped, marking him as an unlikely voyager for such an extended maritime expedition due to his frailty. Nevertheless, he was seated near the captain, cradling a finely crafted brass incense burner in one hand and a talisman made from sea-breath wood in the other.

The venerable priest concentrated as though receiving a transmission beyond the ordinary senses. A hush fell over those present, wary of interrupting his concentration.

After an extended pause, the elder priest finally lifted his gaze.

He had caught various speckles of sensations: the vestiges of a whisper, the faint sound of a final breath, and the odor of decay.

“Over here,” the priest indicated with a raised hand, pointing through the thick fog, “That way.”

Chapter 756: The Far Voyager

In a fog so thick and clinging it felt almost like moving through a dense, sticky substance, the immaculate white exterior of the Sea Song glided forward like a spectral presence.

At first unnoticed by the crew, the once steady roar of the steam core began to transform. It morphed into a strange, low groan that intertwined with layers of echoes. This sound was punctuated by occasional sharp screeches from the pipes, mingled with soft murmurs that resembled the unintelligible whisperings of someone lost in a deep dream.

“The machine seems to have taken on a life of its own…” the priest reported after returning from the engine room to the bridge where the captain stood in command. “The calming effect of the incense we’ve been using is starting to wear off.”

“Sever the connection to the differential engine’s drive shaft, switch every piece of machinery to manual operation, and release some of the steam core’s pressure until it’s back in the yellow zone. Also, change the metal ore catalyst in two hours,” the captain instructed with calm authority. “And reduce the engine room staff’s shifts to three-hour rotations.”

“Yes, captain,” the priest responded, his head bowed in respect. Suddenly, his voice dropped to a hoarse, deep tone, as if a rush of uncontrolled air had forced its way out of his lungs, though it seemed to go unnoticed by those around him. He then turned to leave, and the stern-faced lady captain watched him go before diverting her gaze elsewhere.

Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed a patch of rust beginning to form on the railing next to her seat. It spread slowly, emblematic of the relentless passage of time, years seeming to dissolve before her eyes.

But then, as quickly as it had appeared, the rust vanished from sight as if it were merely a trick of the light. Caught off guard and without a moment to process this anomaly, a deep, vaguely familiar yet eerily unsettling voice whispered directly into her mind:

“Ah… you have come… my little fish… swim, swim… back to the currents…”

The sound of waves gently lapping reached her ears as though she were engulfed by the sea itself, a chilling sensation creeping across her skin. The captain felt momentarily bewildered by the sensation but quickly regained her composure.

From afar, the ship’s first mate’s voice broke through the silence: “Captain! There’s something in the fog!”

This snapped the captain to full alertness, and she immediately turned her attention to the side of the bridge. Peering through the broad expanse of the cabin windows, she caught sight of a faint green glow slowly intensifying within the mist. It seemed as though a massive creature was making its approach, its form gradually becoming more distinct and revealing itself to be another ship.

A colossal ship with a towering bow and sails that appeared almost translucent emerged from the fog, approaching from the side and rear. It caught up to the Sea Song, which was running at full power with an eerie ease. This mysterious vessel was always enveloped in a sort of “distortion” that made it difficult to discern its finer details. However, the Sea Song’s captain instantly recognized the distinct features of this imposing ship—

“It’s the Vanished!” the captain cried out, her voice laced with astonishment, “How did it get here!?”

“That ship has appeared!”

“The Vanished!?”

“Wasn’t it last seen at Wind Harbor?!”

“It’s drawing near!”

These exclamations filled the bridge, creating a cacophony of shock and disbelief. Swiftly, the first mate approached the captain, urgency in his step: “Captain, that ship is closing in on us.”

“…Signal them with the light, ask what they want,” the captain quickly decided, then commanded, “Everyone, to your battle stations. Increase pressure in the church boiler. Remember, we are at the frontier. Do not hastily trust what you see; it may not be the Vanished as we know it.”

Without hesitation, the first mate relayed the orders, and soon, the Sea Song began flashing a series of light signals from its side. These rhythmic pulses of light cut through the dense fog, sending a silent, urgent message across the enigmatic border sea.

All eyes on the bridge were fixed on the shadowy figure of the approaching ship through the fog, which seemed to become even more indistinct and spectral as it neared, resembling a mirage. Suddenly, the captain spotted a bright light flashing near the bow of the Vanished—shining through the mist in a repeating pattern.

Could it be? Had the phantom ship actually acknowledged their signal and was now communicating with them?

The flickering light captured the attention of many on the bridge. The captain scrutinized the signal, her brow furrowed in concentration.

Moments later, the first mate rushed to her side: “Captain, the Vanished has signaled a salute to us… that’s all.”

Confusion momentarily marred the captain’s stoic face, but another development quickly overshadowed this. Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed the shadowy figure of the large ship starting to accelerate away through the fog.

The Vanished unfurled its ghostly sails and silently picked up speed, swiftly surpassing the Sea Song and venturing into the more obscure parts of the sea. Its massive form soon vanished, swallowed by the ever-changing mist.

“That direction is…” the first mate began, a realization dawning on him. He whispered in awe, “Captain, the Vanished is heading towards ‘Him’!”

The captain, however, offered no reply. She remained silent, her gaze fixed on the horizon. It was as if, in the moment the Vanished disappeared, she glimpsed a distant destiny through the fog.

Suddenly, a soft, deep voice resonated in her ears—

“Little fish… you’ve all done well, now it’s time to rest, don’t be afraid… every weary soul has a destination. If you can’t return, this will be your new haven…”

A profound sense of peace enveloped her, touching the very core of her being. With a slight tremor of resolve, the captain gently closed her eyes and murmured, “…Please bear witness…”

When her eyes snapped open again, they shimmered with an unfathomable depth, reflecting a storm within: “…Bear witness to my return journey. My mission is far from complete.”

Fragments of forgotten memories abruptly flooded back into the captain’s consciousness, reigniting the tale of her journey through the disjointed streams of time. She recalled the arduous passage after crossing the

boundary, the myriad challenges and shadows she faced, the obscured sea lying at the fog's end, an ancient island frozen in a moment of time, the colossal temple, the final resting place of titanic creatures, and the deceased deities within the temple—and her homeland, shrouded in perpetual nightfall.

"…You must traverse that boundary… cross the critical threshold of the six miles… They are reaching out to the mortal realm, go seek Them… convey our regards, and return with Their message…"

The counsel given under Queen Helena's crown still resonated within her, though it now seemed like millennia had passed, leaving behind nothing more than a faint memory.

The captain shook her head, her steps leading her toward the helm. Unbeknownst to her, the uniform she once wore with pride had degraded into worn, ragged cloth, and the once orderly and glowing bridge had decayed into a crumbling wreck, worn down by the relentless sea breeze and the passage of time. All illumination had faded, the pervasive fog creeping through shattered windows and blanketing the bridge.

The vessel appeared deserted, devoid of any crew members, as if they had long since departed—remaining forever in the Lord's domain, in that everlasting sanctuary of peace.

As the captain navigated through the desolation, her footing unsteady on the ship that seemed lost to centuries, she caught sight of a figure trembling near the helm.

Likewise, the figure slowly turned to face her.

He appeared desiccated and grotesque as if the sea wind had mummified him over a century, his features contracted and distorted into a visage of horror.

This was no more than a grotesque mummy—but then, the captain realized with a jolt that it was her first mate.

The mummy spoke, its voice grating like coarse stone on stone: “Captain, welcome back to the ship. It seems your retirement is yet to come.”

“…You remained as well.” The captain responded, her voice now just as raspy and chilling as the figure before her.

“Yes, my tasks remain incomplete,” the first mate murmured, “The others have found their rest, but I was haunted by a dream. In it, a ghost ship ablaze with green fire emerged, and you beckoned me to signal it… alas, that signal roused me from sleep. I despise that ship—the Vanished, for it shattered the tranquility bestowed by God… those cursed green flames ensure I’ll never find peace again.”

The captain barely registered the first mate’s bitter recounting—though she noted his drastic changes, her weary mind struggled to focus on these minor details. She simply made her way to the helm, observing the first mate’s efforts there: “Can this ship still embark on a voyage?”

“No,” the first mate replied, turning his head to reveal a ghastly grin, “The steam core ceased to function ages ago, and the hull beneath us has decayed into nothing more than rubble. We’re utterly devoid of any power.”

“…Then what exactly are you attempting to do?”

“I’m trying to make this ship move again, captain,” the first mate explained with deliberate slowness, “If you grasp the steering wheel and will it like a ship… it will begin to move. Believe me, Captain. Eventually, we’ll navigate through this perpetual fog and return to the blasted expanse of the Boundless Sea…”

The captain took a seat, absorbing the first mate’s words. After a considerable silence, she murmured, almost as though she was engaging in

a private conversation with herself: “Then I must also find myself a task.”

“I would advise you to leave behind some form of documentation,” the first mate suggested, “Once we cross that boundary again, it’s uncertain what transformations might occur. The changes could be profound; you might no longer be yourself, and I may evolve further beyond my current state. It’s possible we’ll forget our identities and our actions. Only sacred scripture has the power to offer lasting insight…”

Sacred scriptures…

The captain’s eyelids fluttered slowly, her mind briefly sharpening. With a moment’s pause for consideration, she extended her hand to retrieve something from the pocket of her frayed coat.

What she found was her logbook—a possession of every captain who sailed the sea.

Time had also left its mark on the logbook, yet the paper, sanctified by divine blessing, had resisted the ravages of time and decay; its inscriptions remained legible.

She bowed her head, drawing a pencil from another pocket, and began to inscribe a new entry on its pages—

“I am Captain Caraline of the Sea Song. Herein lies the record of my voyage home…”

“We encountered ‘Him’—approximately fifty years after we crossed the critical threshold beyond the six-mile marker.”

Chapter 757: Misaligned Reflection

Suddenly, the quiet atmosphere above Pland was shattered by a deep, ominous rumble of thunder—mere moments later, the skies opened up, unleashing a heavy, torrential downpour that swathed the small city-state, nestled in the southwest sea region in a dense, misty veil.

The fleeting “light burst,” which had streaked across the heavens only to disappear over the distant horizon of the sea, had left the citizens of Pland in a state of anxious speculation. They were left wondering about the final resting place of those massive, glowing objects that had plummeted from the heavens. This abrupt deluge of rain added an additional layer of foreboding to the atmosphere, transforming the already dark night into an even more impenetrable blanket of darkness. The wind howled mournfully through the streets, and the relentless patter of rain against the windows piled up layer upon layer, stirring feelings of annoyance and unease.

Lawrence made his way through the hotel lobby, observing numerous guests who, stranded by the storm, had congregated near the windows. They engaged in subdued conversations about the mysterious flashes in the sky, the relentless downpour, and the recent departure of a guardian patrol team. Not too far away, the comforting crackle of a warm fireplace filled the space, and the bright glow of electric lights waged a silent battle against the encroaching darkness of the night outside. In this unsettling, rainy backdrop, the flames and light served as beacons of hope, bolstering the ever-weakening sense of security within the hearts of those present.

“It’s just ordinary rain…” A soft reassurance came from the small mirror pinned to Lawrence’s chest as Martha whispered to him, “I’ve checked with the spirit world; there’s nothing to worry about.”

Acknowledging her words with a slight nod, Lawrence peered out the window. The rain smeared the views of the street into a blurry tapestry, with water streaming down the glass, casting distorted patterns of light and shadow. Martha’s reflection briefly appeared on the window, offering him a reassuring smile.

“I’ve just visited the White Oak through the mirror; all is well aboard the ship. There’s no need for concern.”

“Thank you,” Lawrence responded in a hushed tone, barely audible to anyone but himself, “Please be cautious when venturing into the spirit world; our realm has grown perilous.”

“I’m aware,” Martha acknowledged before adding, “Also, I noticed several ships hastily departing from the military port, disappearing into the night heading northeast. Among them were two engineering vessels, equipped with large winches and towing arms.”

“They must be on a mission to recover the ‘fallen object’; it appears a celestial body landed near Pland,” Lawrence quickly deduced, expressing a hopeful sentiment, “…Let’s hope for a smooth operation.”

With a gentle nod, Martha’s image slowly faded from the window pane, leaving Lawrence once again enveloped by the misty curtain of rain and the flowing water.

After a moment of contemplation, the old captain turned away from the window and made his way back through the hotel’s corridors and stairways, heading towards his temporary accommodations on an upper floor. He

retrieved the key to his room, its paint showing signs of wear, and prepared to enter.

However, upon opening the door, Lawrence abruptly halted in his tracks.

In the dead of night, a gaunt, skeletal figure was perched awkwardly on a chair within the confines of the room. The faint glow from a street lamp outside cast its light upon this unanticipated visitor. Upon hearing the sound of the door creaking open, the figure slowly craned his head, unveiling a face as desiccated as a skeleton's, adorned with a macabre grin: "Ah… Captain, you've returned."

The pungent aroma of alcohol immediately assaulted Lawrence's senses.

Raising his hand, Lawrence flicked on the room's light switch, the sudden burst of illumination banishing the shadows and rendering the grotesque figure somewhat less ominous and fearsome. He eyed the intruder with a mix of irritation and concern, asking sternly, "Sailor? Why are you here rather than in your own quarters?"

"Captain…" The Sailor's response came as his head tilted, nearly severing from the neck, hanging grotesquely. Clutching a large bottle of alcohol, he took generous swigs, with the liquid then cascading through the crevices in his chest and neck, pooling onto the floor below. "I found this in my room. I didn't take… hic! Didn't take yours, I'm aware of the rules. Taking from the captain earns one a hanging from the mast…"

Lawrence's initial reaction was one of anger towards Sailor's state, but a feeling of unease quickly took its place. He stepped closer to the corpse-like figure, eyeing the bottle: "What entity has taken hold of you this time?"

As he spoke, Lawrence raised his arm, and a slender thread of ghostly spirit flame danced to life at his fingertips.

Contrary to expectations, Sailor, who would typically react with vigor at the sight of Duncan's ghost fire, showed no sign of alarm. Instead, he merely placed the bottle on the table and looked blankly at the flickering flame, taking several moments before finally lifting his gaze to meet Lawrence's: "Captain, I'm alright, just… recalling some memories."

Lawrence's expression grew more concerned, his gaze fixed on Sailor as he slowly articulated, "…Recalling memories?"

"I once, it appears, truly existed as a human," the corpse made an effort to sit up straighter, an attempt to correct his slouched posture, though he struggled and ultimately failed to do so. "We ventured to a place far beyond, and then… it took an eternity to return to this cursed Boundless Sea…"

…

Frem was abruptly roused from his meditative trance, his peace shattered by a vivid, fiery vision that sent a sharp pang through his head. This towering figure, a member of the forest folk, snapped open his eyes to find himself still in the prayer room, kneeling before the fervently burning fire pit.

The remnants of his vision seemed to flicker within the leaping flames, slowly dissipating as moments passed.

With a growing sense of unease, the Pope's gaze lingered on the fire, his brow furrowing in concentration. Then, as if struck by a sudden realization, he abruptly rose and made his way to the door.

His unexpected emergence took the priests stationed outside the prayer room by surprise. One priest, adorned in a robe of black and red, quickly stepped forward, concern evident in his voice: "What's wrong?"

"I'm heading to the archive," Frem responded curtly, not pausing in his stride. "There's no need for anyone to accompany me. Ensure the fire of the

Chronicle Pillar remains guarded.”

The priests shared a look of confusion among themselves.

But Frem was already advancing down the corridor, leaving the sacred confines of the prayer room behind. His form then seamlessly transformed into a stream of fiery light, weaving through the sanctuary’s myriad of candlesticks, fire pits, and bonfires. In what seemed like an instant, he traversed the entirety of the Ark’s upper reaches, arriving at the heart of the Flame Bearers Ark, beneath the “Great Bonfire,” and into the archive guarded by a massive stone dome. This repository held an immense collection of historical documents, scrolls, and precious stone tablets.

The archive was a well-lit expanse, its heavy, wall-like shelving units arrayed in neat rows within the vast hall. Unlike ordinary bookshelves, these shelves were built on long tracks equipped with hidden traction mechanisms powered by steam engines, enabling them to move between the internal library and the external reading area as needed.

However, Frem’s destination lay beyond these massive shelves, in the “Secret Chamber” nestled deeper within the archive. He bypassed the shelves and tracks, approaching a solid stone wall at the hall’s end, where two knights clad in heavy armor and wielding flame-shaped swords stood guard.

“The Secret Chamber is locked,” one knight declared, his voice muffled by the helm yet unwavering even in the Pope’s presence, diligently adhering to his duty. “May I ask the reason for your visit?”

“I need to consult the stone tablets left by the predecessors,” Frem stated with a gravity that matched his role, “I suspect we are facing an event of historical timeline penetration.”

The knights’ armor clinked softly as they shifted.

“…Time range?” inquired the second knight.

“New City-State Era 1600 to 1755,” Frem specified.

The knights exchanged knowing looks, each taking a synchronized half step to the side while simultaneously raising their flame-shaped swords. They positioned the tips of their swords above designated slots on the ground in front of the stone barrier, one knight casting a cautious glance towards Frem: “Please confirm the current date.”

“New City-State Era 1902, 22nd of the first month.”

As the swords were inserted into the ground slots, the sound of gears and mechanisms echoed through the chamber, and the stone wall began to slowly withdraw, revealing the path forward.

“Confirmed, New City-State Era 1902, 22nd of the first month,” the knights of the Flame Bearers announced with a formal solemnity, “Please ensure your return before today’s end. May your path be safeguarded.”

…

“We have lost communication with the Sea Song,” reported a middle-aged man, his attire signifying his role as a priest of the storm. He stood before Helena, his voice laden with both concern and regret, “After it surpassed the critical distance of six miles, it managed only sporadic contact with the temporary lighthouse for about an hour before silence ensued.”

He hesitated for a moment before continuing: “Following the failure of psychic attempts at communication, we ventured to activate the radio, yet still, no signals were received from the Sea Song.”

Helena remained silent for a moment, absorbing the news, then gave a slow nod of acknowledgment.

“You may leave.”

“Yes, Pope.”

With a respectful bow, the priest exited the room, leaving behind a palpable stillness.

Time passed quietly until Helena stood up, her movements deliberate as she approached the statue of the Storm Goddess Gomona. She offered a sea breath wood amulet to the flames at the feet of the statue, then lifted her gaze towards the deity, shrouded in a sheer shawl.

Beneath the veil, the goddess’s visage remained hidden, as mysterious and unfathomable as the ocean’s depths and the threads of fate.

“…The emissaries we dispatched in search of your domain, have they arrived safely within your realm? Or… have they vanished into the vast, unknown void beyond our world?”

The statue offered no response, and not even the semblance of wave sounds filled the silence.

After what felt like an eternity, Helena exhaled softly, her attention shifting back from the enigmatic statue to the fire pit before her.

“Lune, the vanguard fleet of the Storm Church that we dispatched beyond our borders has ceased to communicate,” she spoke softly into the flames, “Will you still proceed with our plans?”

“Proceed,” came Lune’s voice, emerging from within the fire, “‘Mathematical Law’ is ready and will set sail for the southern boundary in twenty-four hours. We’ve detected a stronger signal in that direction, potentially more promising than the Sea Song.”

As Helena absorbed this information, mulling over her thoughts, her contemplation was suddenly interrupted by an unexpected crackling from the fire pit.

Her eyes widened in surprise as Frem’s voice unexpectedly broke through the flames: “Apologies for the intrusion, but I come bearing crucial intelligence regarding the Sea Song.”

“Frem?” Helena’s voice carried a tone of surprise, followed quickly by realization, “You’re referring to the Sea Song? You’ve come with news?!”

“Yes,” the fire responded with a crackle, Frem’s voice emerging somewhat distorted from the flames, “The Sea Song has made its return.”

“It has returned?” Helena’s astonishment was palpable, her voice tinged with disbelief, “But when? How come I wasn’t informed…”

“1675, the twelf month,” Frem clarified with a calmness that contrasted the bewildering nature of his news.

Chapter 758: The Intelligence Brought by Sailor

Under the cover of darkness, the night sky was briefly lit up by dazzling lights, like pieces of the sun breaking apart, disrupting the otherwise peaceful appearance of the long night. This dramatic event unfolded when a quarter of the mystical runic ring broke apart and plummeted to the world for all to witness. In response, at least seven city-states hastily organized expeditions, launching fleets towards the Boundless Sea to retrieve the glowing fragments that had descended into its depths.

In the first two days of this extended darkness, the Boundless Sea, which had known peace for centuries by this point, teetered on the brink of war like never before.

Thankfully, the situation was defused when the massive fleet of the Truth Academy, led by their formidable flagship “Balance of All Things,” reached the central sea’s largest crash site before any other city-state. By securing the majority of these sun fragments, the Academy reaffirmed the church’s dominance and preserved the delicate peace among the city-states. The competing fleets of various city-states did not engage in battle for the fragments. Instead, they accepted the church’s proposal for distributing them, putting aside their rivalries to ensure that the cities in desperate need of sunlight received the precious fragments.

However, during those tense four hours, an unsettling undercurrent of discord began to silently spread among the numerous city-states

surrounding the Boundless Sea, highlighting the impending struggle over sunlight, now a critical and dwindling resource for survival.

Yet, for Duncan, who remains in Wind Harbor, these events are still distant concerns because he had received unexpected news from Captain Lawrence of the White Oak in regards to Anomaly 077 – Sailor.

Inside the witch's mansion, Lawrence's image materialized in an oval mirror on the wall of the first floor, his voice emanating from it: "…He claimed to have been the first mate aboard the Sea Song, stating they crossed a critical boundary six miles beyond the border on the 21st of the first month, 1902…"

Hearing this, Duncan, who stood by the mirror, showed a puzzled expression: "But today is only the 22nd of the first month of 1902. Are you suggesting… Anomaly 077 was still actively serving as a priest for the Storm Church on a mission across the border just yesterday?!"

Lawrence responded with a grave tone, indicating the seriousness of his claim, "That's exactly what he told me. He mentioned his captain was named Caraline, and he vividly recalled the moment their ship embarked on its journey. He acknowledges it's been only two days since the Sea Song ventured past the border's six miles limit, yet he insisted Captain Caraline and her crew have been adrift for fifty years after crossing that line…"

Duncan remained silent, absorbing the shocking information, while Lucretia, who had overheard the conversation, could only express her astonishment with a gasp: "Fifty years?!"

"Perhaps… even more than that, madam," Lawrence replied, his expression turning serious as he cautiously elaborated. "According to what Sailor has shared, for the initial fifty years, they managed to keep a count of the days using their clear-minded rationality. However, after that period, they completely lost any sense of time. They found themselves adrift in a

perpetual fog, existing in a state that wasn't truly alive but not dead either, reminiscent of those psychiatrists who tragically stumble into 'void faults' at the fringes of dreams while treating patients. Similarly, the Sea Song encountered such a fault at the very edge of our world, and as a result…"

Lawrence momentarily halted, his attention seemingly caught by a sound in his vicinity. Then, a raspy, barely distinguishable voice emerged from the mirror's edge, belonging to Sailor, his voice rough with age: "And so we were 'forgotten,' Captain, ahaha… Forgotten by death, forgotten by the sea, and ultimately, even time and reason ceased to acknowledge us. This led to our becoming undying, eternal wanderers at the edge of the world… But then… hic, by the divine intervention of the goddess, we were once again remembered by Her… And thus, we found our way back to the rightful path… hic!"

Duncan, his forehead creased in thought, quickly seized upon Sailor's words and inquired, "The rightful path you're referring to is…"

"We found Her! A great…" Sailor began to exclaim, his voice growing louder, but he suddenly stopped as though his words were physically stifled. Following a series of indistinct mutterings, he resumed, "I can no longer recall Her appearance, but we truly found… found the source of the call. That was our mission. The Pope had dispatched us in search of Her after She had sent a revelation to Her Grace…"

"Most of us remained behind there; they had no desire to return, to confront a world they deemed already forsaken. The endless drift through the fog had worn away all their once-grand aspirations and steadfast beliefs, and we came across… what was it again? My memory fails me, Captain. I cannot recall it clearly… All I remember is that Captain Caraline and I made it back from the fog. In truth, it was only me. By that point, Captain Caraline had become nothing but a withered shadow, having lost even the memory of her own image, forcing me to assume command of the vessel…"

Sailor’s voice trailed off into a series of unintelligible murmurs, indicative of a mind struggling with clarity. The fleeting memories that had surfaced seemed to whirl around in his deteriorated mind like scattered pieces of a puzzle, leaving him alternately coherent and bewildered.

Duncan, choosing to overlook Sailor’s rambling, reflected briefly before stating, “But now you are known as Anomaly 077—a peculiar entity that was sealed by the city-states many years back. You’ve been manifesting in this realm for centuries, with your first known appearance being aboard an exploration vessel that vanished three years prior.”

Sailor lapsed into silence, not uttering a word for a considerable stretch of time. It was an interval whose length remained undetermined until Lawrence unexpectedly shattered the quiet: “He’s at a loss, he can’t recall how he found his way back to our world, nor the fate of the Sea Song, nor the reasons for his current form, one that conjures storms as an ‘anomaly.’ He observes that the world as it stands now is discordant with the one preserved in his memories, yet he finds himself unable to articulate the specifics of this difference to me.”

Duncan took a moment to absorb this, then exhaled softly.

“I understand. Ensure Anomaly 077 is well looked after first. I’ll get in touch if need be.”

“Understood, Captain.”

As their conversation concluded, the glow within the mirror dimmed, reverting it to a mere reflective surface.

Lawrence’s attention then shifted from the now inert mirror to Anomaly 077, who was seated in the corner of the room, clutching an empty bottle with a vacant expression, its movements repetitive and futile as it tipped the bottle towards its mouth as if expecting an elusive sip.

“Alcohol really has no effect on you,” Lawrence remarked, a note of frustration in his voice as he stood and approached. “You can’t get drunk to alcohol, nor can you be poisoned, and not even a bullet from a gun can harm you. After all, you’ve tested all those methods already.”

The figure halted its pointless motion with the bottle, casting it aside, and after a brief pause, raised its gaze to meet Lawrence’s, its expression listless. “What about a twelve-pound cannon…” it muttered after a delay, its voice carrying a tone of desolation.

“If you’re still around when the end comes, I suppose you could give it a try. Maybe even the sixty-four-pounder at the dock would interest you,” Lawrence said, settling beside the mummy with a hint of humor.

“But considering the world’s end is nigh, such endeavors might be futile. We’re all bound for rest, though your journey has been… unusually circuitous.”

Sailor turned to face Lawrence, his gaze empty.

His eyes, dried and withered, shifted slightly, the brief illusion of inebriation induced by self-delusion fading swiftly. After a moment of vacant staring, the restless entity slowly bowed its head, cradling it within the caverns of his skeletal hands.

“I’ve misplaced the log…” He whispered, his voice a blend of confusion and despair.

“What did you say?”

“The log, Captain Caraline’s diary. She penned much before she disappeared, entrusting me with its return. That was our mission…” The figure’s voice trailed off, its tone verging on the tearful, yet it seemed to have lost the capacity for such distinctly human expressions of grief, “It’s lost, the captain’s diary is lost… I had it with me when the Sea Song

ventured back; it was in my possession, but now its whereabouts elude me… Everything's altered, my memory fails me…"

Lawrence absorbed the somber admission from Sailor, his reaction one of silent astonishment, while Martha's silhouette materialized quietly in the mirror beside him. They both remained motionless, their attention fixed on the mummy. The only sound in the room was the figure's subdued, low-toned mutterings, reminiscent of a being that had long forgotten the art of weeping, now struggling to rediscover how to express sorrow.

…

Turning to face his companions, Duncan realized that a crowd had quietly assembled behind him. Their gazes were divided between him and the now inert mirror that had captured their colleague's reflection.

"…So, that mummy actually has such a remarkable backstory?" Shirley murmured under her breath, a hint of astonishment in her voice.

Deep in thought, Vanna reflected aloud, "The Sea Song, crossing the critical six-mile threshold just a day ago… I recall Her Highness Helena discussing this issue. She mentioned that the major religious orders had begun dispatching advance vessels to penetrate the border boundary, aiming to gather insights from beyond our known world."

"But how does the first mate of a church ship turn into Anomaly 077? They only went into the fog a day ago." Nina expressed her confusion, "And then there's the matter of that 'half-century'…"

"Perhaps… it's an indication that the very notion of 'time' is starting to unravel," Duncan proposed quietly, "Or maybe, this anomaly is intrinsic to the outer sea regions beyond the borders. The Sea Song's crew might have paid the ultimate price to uncover this first property of the boundary."

Upon hearing Duncan’s speculation, Morris’s brow creased in contemplation as if a sudden insight had struck him.

However, before the seasoned scholar could articulate his thoughts, an unexpected knock at the door from the entrance cut through the room, halting his train of thought.

They had a visitor.

Chapter 759: Piercing Through History

As the door swung open, Lucretia was greeted by two figures she recognized but hadn't anticipated seeing at her doorstep. Helena, adorned in a flowing dress the color of the ocean, stood beside Frem, a towering orc whose skin bore the rough texture of stone.

In the distance, the glow of headlights cut through the darkness, belonging to a pair of nondescript steam-powered vehicles stationed near an intersection. A handful of church guardians, motionless as if they were sculptures, kept watch by the cars, blending into the night.

Lucretia's expression soured at the sight of her unexpected visitors. "What's with everyone's sudden fondness for dropping by unannounced?" she asked with a mix of annoyance and curiosity.

"We apologize for the intrusion, Lucretia," Helena began, her tone dismissive of the clear displeasure on Lucretia's face. Without hesitation, she proceeded into the house, her presence commanding yet uninvited. "We need to discuss something of grave importance," she continued, hinting at the secretive nature of their visit, eager to avoid drawing any unwanted attention to their presence.

Before Ms. Lucretia could even think of a response, Helena, the esteemed leader of the Storm Church, had already made her way past the threshold, with Frem trailing behind. He offered a clumsy apology to Lucretia, "My apologies, Ms. Lucretia. Helena has a way of taking matters into her own

hands. We've come because we've stumbled upon something supernatural. It's something that might catch the Captain's interest…"

Lucretia, finding herself unable to halt their advance, could only respond with a sharp retort, "This is my home, you know!" But her protest fell on deaf ears.

Despite her usual aversion to unexpected company, Lucretia found herself powerless to turn away the determined duo. The pair, both high-ranking officials within the church, had effortlessly made their way into her sanctuary. By the time she fully grasped the situation, Helena and Frem had firmly established themselves within her home.

Inside, Duncan, already alerted by the commotion at the entrance, looked up to find Helena and Frem making their entrance. Helena was a familiar face, having visited previously with Lune, but Frem's presence was a novel sight within the city-state, piquing Duncan's interest. "Is it common for popes to roam about so freely? Especially during times like these?" he asked, his tone laced with a light-hearted jest.

Unfazed by Duncan's playful ribbing, Helena seated herself opposite him with a seriousness that belied the gravity of their visit. "We come bearing a message from the divine. News from beyond the threshold of the borders."

Duncan's initial amusement faded, replaced by a sudden intensity as he pieced together the implications of her words. Even Lucretia, approaching with a look of impatience, paused, her expression turning to one of deep thought, recognizing the significance of the information Helena hinted at.

The room fell into a tense silence until Vanna, standing beside the sofa, ventured a guess, "The Sea Song?" Her words cut through the quiet, drawing everyone's attention.

Momentarily caught off guard, Helena adjusted her posture, acknowledging Vanna's insight. "You…" she began, her voice trailing off as she prepared to delve into the heart of their sudden visit.

Duncan initiated the conversation with a sense of purpose, "Had you not come today, I would have sought you out myself," he said, pacing his words thoughtfully. "I've recently come across some information regarding the Sea Song as well. It appears our meeting today is more than mere chance. However, I'm eager to learn what you've uncovered first. What became of that ship?"

Frem and Helena exchanged a meaningful glance before Frem, with a somber expression, took the lead. "The Sea Song made its way back in the year 1675," he announced, his voice heavy with the weight of history.

A hush fell over the room, a silence that was abruptly shattered by Shirley's incredulous outburst, "What? Three hundred and twenty years ago?!"

After a moment of mental calculation, the room sank into an even deeper silence, during which Alice corrected Shirley with a gentle nudge, "Actually, it would be two hundred and twenty years ago…"

Shirley, momentarily taken aback, recalibrated her reaction, "What? Two hundred and twenty years ago?!"

Unaccustomed to such interjections in their discussions, the popes remained silent, unsure of how to respond.

Duncan, familiar with Shirley's occasional lapses in arithmetic, swiftly redirected the conversation back to the matter at hand, "So, the Sea Song returned in 1675? How were you able to verify this?"

Frem responded with a grave tone, "We discovered a disruption in the usual flow of history—a gap, so to speak. I detected this anomaly and then

uncovered corresponding evidence within the stone tablets left by past Flame Bearers…”

He paused, collecting his thoughts before elaborating, “In December 1675, a ship appeared on the eastern frontier. It was in such a state of decay that it seemed almost ghostly and disintegrated into the sea soon after its appearance. The only detail that could be verified before it sank was its name, ‘Sea Song’, etched on its hull.”

“This incident is documented in the Flame Bearers Cathedral archives. Yet, strangely, there is no other record or mention of it in any historical documents or files from that year. It’s as if this event was a shadow, slipping through a crack in history into our reality, observed and remembered solely by the Flame Bearers of that era. In essence, only the bishop’s account from that time has left any ‘mark’ on history.”

Morris, puzzled by the discussion, interjected, “Why would something like this occur? Is it a case of historical contamination? Or perhaps alteration…”

Frem shook his head slowly, “It’s an instance of temporal discontinuity that led to this historical anomaly. The Sea Song must have been displaced from its intended timeline by some mishap, wandering in a 34567 temporal void before finally reentering our world at the ‘1675’ time node…”

After a brief pause for reflection, he further elucidated, “Imagine a tire rolling along, carrying countless specks of dust within it. If one of those specks were to detach from the tire’s inner wall and begin to drift freely, it could reattach itself at any point on the tire’s surface.”

As Frem detailed the concept of being untethered from the traditional flow of time, wandering without chronological anchor, Duncan’s face took on a contemplative expression, his brows knitting together in thought.

Lucretia and Morris, too, seemed to grasp the gravity of Frem's words, their faces lighting up with a dawning understanding as if pieces of a complex puzzle were beginning to fall into place.

In contrast, Alice and Shirley, faced with a theory that ventured far beyond the realm of common understanding, remained visibly unaffected, their clarity of thought seemingly untouched by the intricate discussions of temporal anomalies…

Lucretia, breaking the momentary silence with a soft voice, shared a look of mutual understanding with Duncan, "So, that explains the experiences of Sailor," she mused aloud.

"Sailor?" Helena echoed, her curiosity piqued, evident confusion on her face, "Who's this Sailor you are referring to?"

"The first mate of the Sea Song. He still walks this world, though he is much altered from the man he once was," Duncan revealed, choosing not to withhold the insights gained from Lawrence, and proceeded to share all that he knew over the next few minutes.

Helena and Frem exchanged a glance, absorbing the new information.

After a brief pause, filled with contemplation, Helena spoke up decisively, "I need to meet this Sailor."

"He's currently located near the small city-state of 'Pland', on the southwestern frontier, in the company of another group of my associates," Duncan responded, his tone accommodating. "I can arrange for his return here at any moment, but I prefer to seek his consent first."

Helena seemed momentarily puzzled by this approach, "Seek… his consent?"

Duncan explained, his voice laced with seriousness, "His experiences are beyond what most can fathom, and it's possible that the Sea Song's odyssey

beyond the confines of our known world has closed a ‘historical loop’, causing his memories to resurface almost instantaneously. He may no longer be the person you remember as the first mate of the Sea Song, and he might not wish to engage with anyone from the Storm Church again…”

Helena’s expression softened, a mix of understanding and surprise evident, “It’s somewhat unexpected to hear of your consideration and respect for the feelings of your followers in such matters…”

Duncan’s response was marked by a slight twitch of his mouth, a hint of bemusement in his voice, “And what, exactly, is the image you hold of me?”

Helena quickly tried to correct any misconceptions, “A reliable captain, a respected explorer… We’ve had our misunderstandings, but…”

“Accompanied by an ever-present entourage of shadows from other dimensions, rumored to concoct brews from children and stray dogs from around the world…” Frem chimed in nonchalantly.

Helena: “…”

“That wasn’t my claim,” Frem clarified, looking towards Helena with a stoic expression, “That was a discussion between you and Banster.”

Helena, slightly agitated, retorted, “That was a gross exaggeration! And it was last year! Why bring that up now?”

Unfazed, Frem simply turned his gaze back to Duncan, maintaining his composed demeanor, “They indeed said that.”

A heavy silence fell, broken only by Duncan’s sigh as he turned aside awkwardly.

Lucretia, who had been quietly standing by, now visibly struggled to contain her emotions, her face a portrait of restrained indignation. Her

silence served as a final gesture of respect towards her father.

Finally, after a moment's pause, Duncan resignedly concluded, "…I'll get in touch with Lawrence."

…

"That's the current situation," Lawrence began, positioning himself directly opposite Anomaly 077. His tone was grave, underscoring the seriousness of the matter at hand. "Captain Duncan is eager for a meeting, and the Pope from the Storm Church is also awaiting your decision. Should you choose to, we can set off without delay. The captain has granted me the privilege of utilizing his flame to call forth a portal. Through Ai's capabilities, you could be transported to Wind Harbor almost instantaneously."

By this point, Anomaly 077 had managed to navigate the initial wave of shock and the bewildering flood of memories that had recently returned to him. He had found a semblance of his old self, though now he was grappling with a new wave of anxiety.

"I… am at a loss," he confessed, his voice laced with the tumult of his inner turmoil, making no attempt to mask his feelings from Lawrence. "My memories are a jumbled mess. The days leading up to the Sea Song's departure are particularly hazy. I recognize my role as the first mate of the Sea Song, yet it feels as though I'm looking at a stranger when I ponder this identity… and, perhaps more distressingly, I've misplaced that journal…"

Lawrence paused momentarily, his next words measured, "If it's Captain Caraline's journal that's weighing on your mind…" He trailed off, then continued with deliberate slowness, "It's possible that it hasn't been lost after all."

Sailor's attention snapped up, a flicker of hope crossing his features, "Ah?"

“You’ve mentioned remembering placing her journal by your side just before Captain Caraline vanished, and that you’ve kept it close ever since. The truth is, it has always been near you,” Lawrence explained, locking eyes with Sailor, emphasizing each word with deep sincerity, “Can you recall what has always accompanied you?”

In that moment, Sailor seemed to be piecing together a puzzle, realization dawning upon him slowly.

“It’s the faint traces we discovered on your shroud,” Lawrence revealed, adding another layer to the unfolding mystery.

Chapter 760: Reunion After a Long Separation

The ancient and worn fabric, now resembling more a relic than anything else, bore only fragments of words such as “Caraline,” “border,” and “Leviathan” – their shapes barely discernible. Making out even these few words was a feat, requiring keen observation and the ability to make connections where none seemed to exist.

Anomaly 077 gazed at the fabric laid before him, a piece that had been transferred from the storeroom of the White Oak upon the captain’s command. Since his transformation and induction into the crew of the White Oak, this fabric had been stored away, out of sight in the ship’s containment room.

“It’s been ages since I’ve taken a good look at this… Actually, I don’t think I’ve ever truly seen it for what it is,” Anomaly 077 whispered, his aged fingers gently tracing what seemed like mere stains but were in fact the remnants of faded writings, “I never knew these texts were here…”

“That’s understandable. Unless you’re actively searching for something, it’s easy to overlook these kinds of details, dismissing them as insignificant smudges,” Lawrence replied, his tone nonchalant, “Had Martha not been so observant and considered this angle, we might never have linked these smudges on the fabric to Captain Caraline’s diary. Especially now, when so little of it is left… The elements have claimed nearly all its substance.”

“Yes, there’s hardly anything left…” Sailor responded, his voice filled with a sense of loss, “It’s hard to believe this was once the captain’s detailed log. Now, what remains is barely coherent… It was meant to be a comprehensive record, not this… ‘fabric’…”

“This transformation likely relates to your journey back from the realm beyond the border to the Boundless Sea. Crossing that six-mile threshold seems to irrevocably alter the essence of certain objects,” Lawrence speculated, “It turned you into Anomaly 077 and transformed Captain Caraline’s detailed log into this piece of fabric—but regardless, these fragments are vital clues, and ‘he’ needs them.”

Sailor stood silently next to the fabric, engulfed in a profound stillness. An inner turmoil seemed to grip him; after a lengthy pause, he gave a slow nod.

“Alright, lead me to him. ‘He’ has been waiting for too long.”

Lawrence let out a quiet sigh, stepping back slightly. Almost immediately, a ghostly green flame flickered into existence where he had just stood. The heart of the flame then twisted and contracted before expanding and pulsing, and from this fiery maelstrom emerged a skeletal bird, its visage striking terror!

The appearance of the skeletal bird and the swirling portal of flame immediately caused Sailor to take a half step back, his gaze shifting from the rotating flames to the creature circling near the ceiling before he turned to Lawrence with a look of disbelief, “…Is this thing really safe?”

“Are you having second thoughts now?” Lawrence’s eyes widened in surprise, his tone incredulous, “You’re not seriously reconsidering at this moment, are you? If ‘he’ has to come personally to fetch you, it won’t be nearly as gentle as this!”

Feeling the weight of Lawrence’s words, Sailor visibly tensed, a look of inner conflict crossing his face as he hesitantly moved two steps towards the flame portal, stopping mid-way with a question, “Does passing through hurt?”

Without a word, Lawrence moved closer, positioning himself just behind Sailor.

Sailor’s whole body seemed to react, shuddering as if feeling a chill he hadn’t experienced in centuries, “No, no, no, I’ll go, I’ll go in myself…”

With that declaration, he approached the swirling flames, bracing himself before tentatively reaching a hand into the vortex, only to quickly retract it, exclaiming, “Ah damn, it’s kind of hot… Captain, isn’t there another way…”

Lawrence, losing patience, gave him a nudge: “Quit your complaining!”

Sailor’s startled yelp was swiftly swallowed by the roaring flames.

“Get a move on! Get a move on!” The skeletal bird screeched, diving into the flame portal. However, in a surprising turn, it reemerged from the portal a moment later, seizing the neglected shroud with its claws before disappearing back into the flames.

Lawrence let out a weary sigh.

Just as he was about to leave, the flame portal burst open once more, and the giant bird reappeared, approaching Lawrence with an urgent, grating demand, “Get some fries, get some fries, get fries…”

Lawrence nearly jumped out of his skin at this unexpected request from the “messenger,” stumbling back to regain his composure. It dawned on him then that he had forgotten to prepare the necessary “offering” and “medium” for the summoning, his forehead beading with sweat, “I… forgot to prepare…”

The skeletal bird fixed Lawrence with a stare, its empty, flame-filled eye sockets boring into him, causing Lawrence to stiffen.

In those tense moments, Lawrence's mind raced through various notorious incidents among the Boundless Sea's captains involving summoning and sacrifices: a wizard met his end against a wall, crushed by the violent backlash for presenting an incorrect offering to a spirit from the shadow realm; a cultist was fatally struck down by an irate demon for an inadequate sacrifice; a Truth Saint, while examining an ancient artifact, inadvertently activated a spell to call forth malevolent spirits and, lacking a proper offering, was forced to eliminate the uncontrollable entity in a desperate struggle…

Uncertain how to interpret the behavior of the peculiar messenger known as "Ai" that the captain frequently mentioned, Lawrence quickly realized that confronting this entity with aggression was likely not an option. The idea of physically overpowering Ai, much less resorting to violence, seemed increasingly impractical as he contemplated the situation.

With a nervous gulp, Lawrence began to second-guess his earlier oversight. Given their allegiance to Captain Duncan, it was uncertain whether Ai, this seemingly otherworldly "messenger," would recognize the concept of camaraderie or allegiance among the crew.

His thoughts were interrupted when he noticed Ai, the skeletal bird, suddenly pull back, turn around, and head back through the portal, all the while muttering under its breath about the indignities of its position: "Slave labor, not even compensated for overtime…"

With that, Ai and the portal vanished from the room, leaving Lawrence in a state of bewildered silence.

…

Meanwhile, Duncan observed Anomaly 077 being unceremoniously ejected from the portal by Ai. He then turned his attention to a visibly agitated dove pacing on the coffee table, puzzled by its demeanor: “What seems to be the issue with this bird now?”

Alice, equally baffled, responded, “I’m not sure. She appears to be quite upset…”

“Let’s not dwell on it. Perhaps feeding her will improve its mood,” Duncan suggested nonchalantly, dismissing the matter with a wave of his hand and turning his focus back to Anomaly 077, who was struggling to regain his footing.

“It’s been a while, Sailor.”

Upon hearing Duncan’s greeting, Anomaly 077, who had been cautiously avoiding making eye contact with anyone in the room, stiffened. It was as if the direct address confirmed there was no escaping this reunion. He slowly stood up straighter, his nervous gaze scanning the room.

“Uh… Captain, it’s been a long time, and everyone else, too… I haven’t seen any of you in quite a while…”

He proceeded to greet each person in the room, reverting to the formality he once displayed in Duncan’s presence, but then he halted abruptly when he met Helena’s gaze.

Responsible for the Storm Church, Helena watched the mummified figure before her intently. She scrutinized Anomaly 077’s desiccated and ghastly form, her expression gradually shifting as she endeavored to reconcile the sight before her with her memory of the Sea Song’s loyal first mate, whom she had met personally not too long ago. Despite her efforts, she found it impossible to associate the dignified first mate with the disfigured, hunched figure of Anomaly 077.

After a moment of silence, Helena spoke, breaking the tension: “I can’t recognize you.”

“Yes, it has been over two hundred years—perhaps even longer,” Anomaly 077 responded with a grin that produced a grating sound. He took a few steps toward Helena, attempting a polite gesture, but hesitated, his hand faltering mid-air, “…I’ve forgotten how to make that gesture properly.”

Helena’s query carried a weight of formality rather than genuine curiosity, “Are you the Sea Song’s first mate?”

“Yes, as far as my scattered memories can confirm,” Sailor replied, tapping his temple as if to summon clarity from the chaos within, “What remains in my mind are fragmented pieces. I vividly recall the moment before we embarked on our journey. Captain Caraline and I were aboard the Ark, under your watchful eye, receiving your sacred blessing. You anointed our wrists with ointment… The day had not yet yielded to night.”

Helena paused momentarily, her acknowledgment tinged with a sense of temporal proximity, “…Yes, that was relatively recent.”

“To me, it feels like eons have passed,” Sailor said softly, turning his gaze towards Duncan, “I’ve shared everything I can recall. Captain Lawrence must have already briefed you on any details I’ve omitted, correct?”

Duncan offered a nod of confirmation as he approached the low table, his hand unhesitatingly grasping the filthy, shredded “cloth”—its unsightly condition notwithstanding: “Is this the shroud Lawrence referred to?”

As Duncan’s fingers made contact with the cloth, all eyes in the room shifted towards him. Sailor confirmed with a nod, “Yes, that’s the one… It bears Captain Caraline’s handwriting, though I’m at a loss as to how it ended up in this state. It’s supposed to be the Sea Song captain’s log…

Captain Caraline entrusted it to me before she disappeared. It's one of the few memories I hold with absolute clarity."

Duncan scrutinized the dilapidated fabric, its inscriptions barely discernible, his expression morphing into a frown, "…It's illegible now."

"The transition back to the Boundless Sea likely caused its current state," Sailor lamented, shaking his head in resignation, "That boundary… It acts as a barrier, preventing us from transporting secrets from beyond back to our world."

Duncan absorbed the information in silence, his contemplation casting a reflective mood over the room. The quiet was so profound that the only sound was the clock's ticking, marking the passage of time in the otherwise still atmosphere.

Breaking the silence, Duncan finally looked up, a decisive tone in his voice, "Would you object if I were to conduct some 'extreme' tests on it?"

Chapter 761: Captain Caralines Log

The moment Duncan began to speak, Sailor was struck with an immediate realization of what the captain intended to do. This insight wasn't new; ever since Lawrence had awakened him aboard the White Oak, Sailor's greatest fear had become a stark reality: the terror of being ignited into flames by Captain Duncan.

Regrettably, this fear had materialized when Sailor was struck by a colossal fireball, a deadly gift from a messenger known as "Ai."

Having endured the horror of being engulfed in ghost fire, which seemed capable of vaporizing his very soul at any moment, Sailor was understandably on edge, voicing his concern with a tremble in his voice, "…Will this directly set the shroud ablaze?"

"Theoretically, it shouldn't," Duncan replied with unwavering confidence. "I possess the ability to fine-tune my flames to reveal the hidden 'reality' beneath the facade of various mystical objects. This technique has allowed me to safely examine and discover secrets of numerous artifacts in the past…"

Before Duncan could further assure him, the conversation took a turn as Shirley, who had been listening intently, interjected with a reminder, "Except, that black leather book we retrieved from the Annihilators was reduced to ashes after you merely glanced at it…"

Not to be outdone, Nina chimed in with her own example, “And let’s not forget the golden mask from the Suntists in Pland that also succumbed to flames…”

“Atlantis too burned not long ago…” Lucretia added softly, highlighting the recent event.

Faced with these reminders, Duncan’s confident facade began to crumble, and the air filled with a palpable tension. However, Alice, who had been distractedly feeding pigeons, sensed an opportunity to lighten the mood and eagerly interjected, “But my wooden box didn’t burn!”

After a brief pause, she continued with a grave tone, “Though, it did become part of the Vanished after the captain ‘inspected’ it…”

Trying to maintain his composure, Duncan managed to address Alice with a strained smile, suggesting she could’ve omitted that last detail before turning back to Sailor. Despite the awkward exchanges, he endeavored to project an air of assurance, “…Regardless, it’s extremely safe.”

Sailor, observing the captain’s strained dignity and the mixed reactions of the crew and the two impassive popes, took a moment before reluctantly offering his trust, “I believe.”

With a palpable sense of relief, Duncan approached Sailor, placing a comforting hand on his shoulder, “Don’t worry, I recognize its value as potentially the last remnant of the Sea Song. I’ll handle it with utmost care.”

Acknowledging Duncan’s pledge, Sailor nodded, albeit still somewhat dazed by the gravity of the situation. Duncan then proceeded to a low table, where he solemnly laid out the shroud, his demeanor reflecting the seriousness of the task at hand.

Helena and Frem found their attention inexorably drawn to Duncan’s actions. After a moment of hesitation, filled with the weight of the

responsibility they bore, Frem felt compelled to voice his concern, “This is the sole piece of ‘knowledge’ that has made its way back from the uncharted territories. Should there be any indication of harm, I implore you to cease immediately.”

“I understand,” Duncan responded with a gravitas that matched the significance of the moment. With the eyes of his companions fixed upon him, he carefully positioned his hand above the ancient shroud.

“…Let me have a word with it,” he whispered under his breath, a soft murmur meant only for himself.

From his fingertips, a stream of ethereal flame, resembling liquid more than fire, sparked to life and gently descended upon the shroud. With the fluidity of water, this ghost fire instantly permeated the fabric, seeping into every crease and fold as it explored the hidden secrets within.

Duncan, with his eyes gently closed, focused intently on guiding the flames as they wove through the shroud. He was deeply attuned to the fragments of information being relayed through the fire, seeking to connect with a reality that was fractured, remote, and seemingly lost to time. Though familiar to him, this process required a level of concentration and precision he had honed over many such endeavors.

In the realm of his perception, a tumultuous void unfolded, initially revealing nothing but the chaotic absence of form or structure.

However, abruptly, as if a lost era had been plucked from the annals of history and thrust into the present, a faint illumination pierced the void within this tumult.

Feeling a pull towards this light, Duncan advanced mentally, and before he could fully engage with it, a soft, indistinct voice reached him:

“I am Caraline, the captain of the Sea Song, and this message is what I’ve managed to send back from our journey…”

“We encountered ‘Her’—roughly fifty years after we crossed the critical six miles limit…”

At this revelation, Duncan’s metaphorical eyes widened in his visionary state. The light amidst the chaos began to take shape, forming the silhouette of a woman donned in the Storm Church’s naval attire. Her stature was imposing, yet her features remained obscured.

She seemed to stand alone, speaking to the ether, unaware of Duncan’s presence or observation.

“…Beyond the frontier, time is not linear. It took years of being adrift to understand that the six miles critical limit is more than a physical demarcation; it defines the limits of our world’s order…”

“In the mists, detached from the familiar flow of time, I witnessed an array of surreal visions. In the densest fog, the very edge of our world appeared to crumble and decay…”

“…There, the specters of explorers lost to the frontier, devoid of both substance and self-awareness, roamed. Caught in a tumultuous, disjointed temporal stream, they moved without purpose, like fog, coalescing and dispersing. The Sea Song encountered some of these phantoms, and through these interactions, I came to realize we were beginning to mirror their fate…”

“My crew, they began to lose their sense of self, transforming into something unrecognizable after nearly fifty years adrift. This realization came to me much later, and by that time, I was scarcely in better condition than they were…”

“…Throughout it all, the first mate remained steadfast at his post… His endurance is beyond my comprehension…”

“Then, as if by some miracle, we found ourselves once again amidst the call of the waves, drawn to a suddenly materializing sea. This sea ‘pulled’ the Sea Song towards an island. I came to my senses then, astonished that such a vast physical expanse could exist beyond the known frontiers. It was then I understood that these ‘islands’ were actually the sacred resting grounds of our deity.”

“There she was, the sovereign of storms, the essence of the deep sea, the goddess Gomona…”

“The revelations I share may astonish or unsettle many, yet they are the truth of my experiences.”

“The realm of the divine is not situated in a ‘higher’ dimensional plane, nor does it lie at the ‘foundation’ of our universe. The concept of a divine kingdom as a distinct place is a fallacy; the gods have always been amongst us… encircling the world, beyond the mists at the edge of our reality. They, and their offsprings, form part of the ‘outer barrier’.”

At this point, Caraline’s phantom paused, her narrative interrupted by a gap in her recollection. Duncan, drawn in by her account, sought to engage with the captain’s visage, questioning the nature of her revelations.

“The gods encircle the world and are integral to the outer barrier?” he inquired abruptly, “What lies beyond this barrier? What exists further out? Were you able to see it?”

The phantom of Caraline offered no reply, trapped within the confines of her recorded message. After a brief silence, she resumed her account, still echoing Captain Caraline’s words:

“…Many of us remained there.”

“The goddess of storms slumbers at the heart of those primeval islands… these ‘islands’ are in truth the carcasses of Leviathans, arrayed around the sea, cradling Her in their midst… the largest of these hosts a temple, a structure reminiscent of a tiered obelisk, crafted from an amalgam of dark green and pitch-black stones, adorned with enigmatic, convoluted markings that hint at some form of script, though none I recognize…”

“The entity at the temple’s core is beyond description, differing vastly from any preconceived notion of the goddess I held. In the moment I beheld Her form, it felt as though my consciousness was shattered and reconstituted countless times. Yet, it was a soft voice that restored us, a voice that integrated us into ‘Her’ being, shielding us from dissolution into the formless entities of the mist…”

“Then, She expressed her regret to us.”

“She confessed her inability to maintain control. She revealed that she had perished yet struggled against the encroach of death. Now, She required our assistance.”

“She tasked me with delineating a pathway, a specific course leading from the Boundless Sea directly to the outer barrier. Only through navigating the correct route within the fog that lies between the boundary of the six miles limit can travelers hope to reach ‘Them’…”

“It was essential for someone to make the journey back to bring this information.”

As Caraline’s spectral form spoke, her head bowed gently, her voice carrying a tone of solemnity.

“Exhaustion had claimed most of my crew; they opted for a final rest in the divine anchorage of the Lord… I harbor no resentment towards their choice, for it is an intrinsic aspect of ‘humanity’ to seek solace.

“In the end, it was just my first mate and I who embarked on the journey back to familiar shores. The Sea Song had been claimed by the islands, yet the goddess crafted its semblance from the mist before its complete engulfment. My first mate and I boarded this spectral ship, guided by the direction she imparted, navigating back towards home…”

“Now, the end of our voyage draws near.”

“I sense the gradual fading of my own existence, as well as that of the Sea Song… we are but phantoms conjured by the goddess amidst the fog, and the tangible world does not permit such phantasms to linger… this sensation of fading, it signifies our nearing home.”

“Yet, my first mate and I are not the same. He is no illusion birthed from the mist; he has remained vigilant throughout our journey, from our departure until this moment, manifesting tangibly within this realm, loyally executing his duties.”

“Hence, the responsibility of the route falls to him… he carries the knowledge to navigate back to our world, and equally, to return to those islands… regardless of the passage of time.”

“I am Caraline, captain of the Sea Song, and I bequeath the entirety of the Sea Song to my devoted first mate, marking this as the final entry I record as captain.”

“Goddess, please bear witness…”

Within the enveloping chaos and dense fog, the luminous figure of Caraline stilled into silence once more.

Then, as the fog lifted, Duncan found himself returning to his senses—he was back in the living room, surrounded by the familiar yet now seemingly distant reality of his own world.

Chapter 762: The Temporary Sailor

As soon as Duncan regained consciousness, everyone quickly converged around him, eager to hear what he had experienced. The eerie, soft glow of a ghostly green flame, which seemed almost alive in its gentle ripple, was still visible, nestled within the creases of the shroud surrounding him. With a slight blink, Duncan managed to quell the flame, preventing it from fully engulfing the shroud in its ethereal fire. He took a brief moment to collect his thoughts, piecing together the vision he had just witnessed before his eyes landed on the mummy.

Sailor stood at a cautious distance, yet its curiosity got the better of it as it seemed to lean forward slightly, its demeanor a mix of hesitation and intrigue.

With a blend of concern and curiosity etching her youthful face, Nina approached Duncan. “Uncle Duncan, what did you see?” she asked, her voice tinged with an earnest need for answers, gently tugging at his arm.

Opting for transparency, Duncan responded without any attempt at evasion, “…Captain Caraline’s memories,” his voice soft yet clear. “It showed me what happened after the Sea Song was lost at sea and how they managed to find their way back home…”

At the mention of these events, Sailor’s interest was visibly piqued, and it edged closer to the group, drawn in by the narrative unfolding.

Withholding no details, Duncan recounted everything revealed to him in the vision. Upon concluding his tale, all eyes instinctively turned towards Sailor, who had subtly moved to stand beside the coffee table by now.

Caught in the moment, Anomaly 077 was momentarily absorbed in the story until Duncan mentioned Captain Caraline entrusting him with the route to the outer world. This revelation caught him off-guard, causing his demeanor to shift abruptly as he took a step back, his eyes widening in disbelief. “Hey, don’t look at me, I don’t know anything about the route, what route… I’m clueless!” he protested, his hands gesturing his ignorance.

Helena, skepticism evident in her expression, pressed him, “You don’t know?” She was puzzled. “Captain Caraline said she entrusted that route to you… Do you not remember anything?”

“I don’t!” His response was a mix of confusion and a hint of panic, his arms spread wide in a gesture of complete bewilderment. “I vaguely remember something about the log… But, honestly, I can barely recall my own journey back!”

Frem, the tall and usually silent orc, studied him for a moment before posing his question, “Then what else do you remember? After returning to the Boundless Sea, do you not have any other more vivid memories?”

This prompted Sailor to think deeply until a moment of realization struck him. “Yes, I remember waking up in a box, with two individuals draped in blue and black robes sprinkling bone dust and spices over me. And there was another, as big as you, Frem, poised to seal the coffin with me inside. I resisted, and in response, he struck me with a hammer blow. The next thing I knew, it was 1864.”

The revelation hung in the air, leaving a brief silence in the room, punctuated by an awkward atmosphere. Alice, seemingly unfazed by the

tension, leaned in with genuine interest, “Ah, then what happened?” Her question broke the brief lull, her curiosity undimmed.

Following Sailor’s recount of waking up to a second hammer blow in 1901, the mood in the living room shifted as everyone exchanged knowing looks. Helena let out a cough to break the tension, and with a helpless shrug, Duncan signaled a mutual desire to steer the conversation away from these unsettling tales of resurrection and hammering.

Undeterred by the awkward atmosphere, Alice’s curiosity remained piqued. She leaned in closer to Sailor, her voice tinged with genuine intrigue, “Hey, how did you know it was 1864? Weren’t you just knocked unconscious when you woke up?”

Sailor explained that he had later asked Captain Lawrence, who informed him that historical records mentioned only that one incident where he nearly lost control completely. He added, “Besides, I actually woke up several times, but those memories are a blur…”

Alice, ever so interested, inquired about his sleep quality, to which he replied, “Not bad, the chanting was never too loud. Though now, I spend half my time out of the box since the captain gave me a bed…”

Their exchange, veering into an oddly casual chat about sleeping arrangements, was abruptly interrupted by Duncan, who felt compelled to steer the conversation back to the pressing matter at hand. Clearing his throat, he interjected, “Ahem, now is not the time for this.”

With the room’s attention back on him, Sailor ceased his banter.

Duncan then addressed Anomaly 077 directly, acknowledging Sailor’s forgotten memories regarding the ‘route’ but also suggesting that what Captain Caraline recorded in her log held equal weight. “The ‘route’ might not have been something you were simply supposed to remember. Captain

Caraline's words, 'entrusted the route to you,' suggest she might have passed on this information in a more tangible form, anticipating that there might come a day when mere memory wouldn't suffice."

Duncan's theory suggested that just as Captain Caraline's log had traversed boundaries in a tangible form, she might have employed a similar method to ensure the 'route' remained with Sailor unaffected by any alterations to memory or self-awareness. "This 'route' could still exist with you, in a form we've yet to comprehend," he concluded, hinting at a mystery deeply intertwined with Sailor's own being and possibly hidden within the enigmatic shroud or another form entirely, waiting to be discovered.

As Sailor absorbed Duncan's hypothesis, a flicker of acceptance crossed his face, tempered by skepticism. "…Could Captain Caraline really have implemented such a method? I always assumed her log's transformation was an unintended mishap… She was, after all, only human…"

Helena interjected with a perspective that lent the conversation a deeper significance, "But she once stood before our Lord," her voice cutting through the silence with a hint of reverence. "Any human who has looked into the face of a god… can scarcely be deemed ordinary anymore."

This assertion left Sailor speechless, contemplating the weight of Helena's words.

Seizing the moment to outline the next steps, Duncan fixed his gaze upon Anomaly 077 with renewed intensity. "We'll need time to determine how we might uncover the information that's purportedly within you," he said, his tone underscored with seriousness. "For now, you'll remain with us. And when the time comes, be ready to join the Vanished on our voyage."

The prospect of a prolonged commitment seemed to catch Sailor off guard, his initial shock palpable. "Ah? I assumed my role was merely to pass on what I knew…"

Duncan’s silent stare prompted a swift adjustment in Sailor’s demeanor, his expression hardening with resolve. “Of course, as you’re well aware, my allegiance to the Vanished Fleet is unwavering. To board that legendary vessel has always been the dream of my lifetime…”

A softening smile from Duncan eased the tension, mirrored by the others’ encouraging grins. In a gesture of camaraderie, Shirley gently patted Sailor’s skinny arm, offering words of reassurance, “Don’t fret, the captain is truly kind. And life aboard the ship is far from dull. Every day is an adventure…”

She then left unsaid her own role in contributing to the ship’s “adventures.”

The moment, though light-hearted, was not lost on Helena, whose gaze carried a mix of emotions. The memory of those warriors who had sought her blessing prior to the Sea Song’s departure, their vibrant faith now a stark contrast to the present, weighed heavily on her.

“It’s time we departed,” Helena finally declared, her voice tinged with a hint of melancholy, acknowledging the length of their visit and the duties awaiting her and Frem at the church.

Noting the mechanical clock’s late hour, Duncan acknowledged their need to leave without the customary farewell, citing his own preparations as his focus.

As Helena and Frem made to exit, Helena paused, turning back towards Duncan with a momentary hesitation. She then imparted crucial information, “The Storm Church’s border assembly point lies in the southeastern border, close to the waters where you last encountered the ‘Tide.’”

Duncan’s acknowledgment was subtle yet firm, “Understood. I’ll reach out before we embark.”

This exchange, layered with unspoken understandings and commitments, underscored the gravity of their shared cause and the uncertain journey ahead.

After the departure of the two popes, the night swallowed the sounds of their cars fading into the distance. Once abuzz with conversation and speculation, the living room settled into a brief silence. It was Shirley who broke the quiet, unable to suppress a wide yawn, signaling the night's toll on her, "Aooo… I'm sleepy, I'm going to bed!"

Following Shirley's lead, Vanna and Morris also excused themselves, leaving the room in search of rest.

Assuming her role as the hostess, Lucretia turned her attention to making the "new member" of their unusual household comfortable. She eyed the mummy with a practical gaze, inquiring about his lodging preferences, "There are plenty of empty rooms here. Do you have any preferences for the room? Floor level or ventilation?"

The mummy, taken aback by the consideration, quickly dismissed the need for any special arrangements, "No need, no need," he said, waving his hands in a dismissive gesture, his voice tinged with nervousness, "Just find me a place to stay, I don't sleep anyway…"

His attention drifted to the stair railing nearby, an idea sparking in his eyes. "Hey, this railing is nice. Just give me a rope, and I can hang here, facing the sun, perfect for sunbathing in the morning… Oh, although there hasn't been much sun recently…"

Duncan, intrigued yet skeptical, arched an eyebrow, "Are you sure? Just so you know, Nina wakes up the earliest, and that girl can be quite groggy in the morning. If she groggily comes down the stairs and looks up to see you hanging on the railing, it won't just be a simple scare—you'll really be seeing the sun."

Lucretia, overhearing this plan, was immediately flustered and insisted, “You must stay in a room!” Her tone was firm, almost motherly in her concern, “Don’t scare Nina—then I’ll have no house left.”

Nina, who had been quietly listening behind Duncan, chimed in with a small, meek voice, “Actually, I’ve got it pretty under control now…”

Observing the interplay between Captain Duncan, Miss Witch, and the “sun fragment” expressing her grievances in a softly wronged tone, Sailor sensed an atmosphere far removed from what he had anticipated.

Intrigued and perhaps a bit amused by the domestic dynamics at play, he couldn’t help but let a smile creep across his face—a smile that, despite its intent to be reassuring, carried an eerie quality.

“Alright, I’ll follow your arrangement.” His agreement, while grudging, signified his willingness to embrace the peculiarities of his new surroundings.

Chapter 763: Before the Long Voyage

Sailor had recently become a unique addition to the inhabitants of the “Witch’s Mansion,” though his presence seemed to barely ripple through the daily life within the mansion’s walls.

Unlike any ordinary person, Sailor had the peculiar ability to remain stationary for extended periods, much like a mummified corpse. He required neither sustenance nor sleep. If left unaddressed, he might spend days without uttering a single word, often found in his secluded corner, lost in thought or staring blankly into space, giving the impression he was in a perpetual state of contemplation or disconnection from his surroundings.

This unusual behavior almost led the other residents to occasionally forget the presence of an extra occupant within the mansion.

Interaction between Sailor and others was minimal, with the exception of Luni. Their exchanges were brief and functional, mainly consisting of simple requests and responses such as, “Ah, could you shift a bit to the side?” followed by a quiet “Yeah.” Once the task was completed, “Alright, you can move back now,” would be met with a nonchalant “Oh.”

As days turned into a routine, a curious incident occurred on the third day that prompted Lucretia, the mansion’s mistress, to confront Sailor. She found him in the basement storage room, sprawled amidst various items, mimicking a corpse. She expressed her bafflement, recounting tales from

her father about Sailor’s once vibrant and active demeanor aboard the White Oak, questioning why he had adopted such a subdued presence in her home.

In response, Sailor, while maintaining his position among the clutter, locked eyes with Lucretia in the dim light and posed a question, “Is it bad to seek calm?” He suggested that his calmness was intentional, hinting at a preference for peace and quiet, possibly shared by Lucretia herself.

Lucretia attempted to articulate her thoughts but was swiftly interrupted by Sailor’s revelation. He explained his current state as a form of preparation, conserving energy for an upcoming, significant journey that seemed to be in the planning stages. Despite the captain’s silence on the matter, Sailor was convinced of the impending voyage and had been instructed to rest and attempt to recollect anything related to the Sea Song.

Curious, Lucretia inquired about his recollections, to which Sailor shared vague memories of life aboard the Sea Song—highlighting the disorder, the noise from the crew during the second shift, and an endless omnipresent fog. He concluded, somewhat apologetically, that despite the captain’s confidence, he had yet to remember anything specific about the ‘route’ they were to undertake.

It was a bold move to exhibit such a lackadaisical attitude in the presence of the Sea Witch. Her eyebrows arched in a reflex of surprise at Sailor’s audacity, but she quickly masked her reaction, resuming her typically impassive demeanor, “Father always has his methods.”

Sailor, sprawled amid the mess, nonchalantly smacked his lips before abruptly shifting the conversation, “What about you? Is your Bright Star ready to set sail?”

Lucretia offered no verbal response, her expression tightening into a frown.

Observing her closely, Sailor noted, “You’re still resistant. I can see your hesitation,” his voice calm yet carrying an underlying seriousness, “I somewhat understand what you’re resisting… but please, be prepared. This voyage might turn out to be the greatest in history, perhaps even the last. This time, at least, you have the choice to embark alongside your father…”

His words prompted a silent but intense stare from Lucretia, compelling Sailor to halt his speech.

“Has anyone ever told you that you talk too much?”

He pondered briefly, “…I’ve been here three days, and only today have I spoken this much… alright, I’ll hold my tongue.”

Lucretia watched him silently for a moment longer before redirecting her attention towards the door, stating, “The Bright Star is always ready for a long voyage.”

However, as she initiated her departure, Sailor halted her, “Hey, wait a moment, there’s one more thing…”

Curiosity piqued, Lucretia turned back, inquiring, “What is it?”

“Could you help me reconnect my spine and shoulder…” he continued, his posture still lax in the heap of clutter, evidently having dislocated a joint during his earlier lazy stretch.

Lucretia’s face subtly shifted as she regarded him, but then she decisively turned and exited without offering assistance, “Just lie there.”

…

The scene transitions to Duncan, who paused his writing to glance towards the window. Despite the darkness outside, the bright indoor light bathed the study. Alice sat quietly by the window, the light gently illuminating her, her eyes nearly closed as if on the brink of sleep.

Her attention snapped to Duncan as he observed her from his desk, her face lighting up with a smile, “Captain! Have you finished writing?”

Alice’s curiosity was apparent when approaching Duncan, even though she knew she couldn’t decipher the contents of the captain’s diary on the desk.

“I’m done. If you’re tired, you don’t need to stay here on my account. Go rest in your room.” Duncan answered.

“I’m not tired!” Alice quickly responded, her eyes momentarily caught by the cryptic entries in the captain’s diary, “Is this your diary? Uh… I can’t understand a single word…”

Duncan offered a warm smile, choosing not to delve into the intricacies of diary writing but instead posed a simple question, “Do you want to try writing a diary?”

Alice, caught off guard by the suggestion, hesitated before responding, “Me? I don’t even know where to begin… I’m not sure what to write about, and doesn’t it require a vast vocabulary?”

Her concerns were met with Duncan’s laughter, an encouragement in its melody, “You just write about anything that feels important or captures your interest. A diary isn’t about showcasing a vast vocabulary; the words you already know are sufficient. And if words fail you, why not express yourself through drawings?”

As Alice absorbed his words, her initial hesitation transformed into enthusiasm, “I can draw!” she exclaimed with a newfound joy.

Her declaration of artistic ability was modest, to say the least. Duncan had taught her the basics of drawing, enabling her to produce simple sketches that could be recognized as either a man, a woman, a person, or perhaps Dog. Despite the simplicity of her skills, she held a proud belief in her ability to “draw.”

Seeing her excitement, Duncan reached into his desk, retrieving a brand-new diary and a pencil, which he then offered to Alice, “This is for you, a little something I brought back from the ship. It’s a place for you to keep the memories you cherish.”

Alice’s delight was palpable as she accepted the diary, eagerly flipping through its blank pages before settling down next to the desk, poised to write. However, curiosity got the better of her, and she asked, “Why do you suddenly want me to start a diary?”

Duncan paused, taken aback by the question. After a moment’s reflection, he shared his rationale, “We’re on the cusp of a journey to places far and unknown, where we’re bound to experience a myriad of sights and events. Memories can be elusive, and to ensure you don’t lose sight of the journey’s essence, it’s wise to anchor them in writing.”

Alice seemed to grasp the significance of his words, showing a flicker of comprehension before nodding earnestly. She then focused on the diary, inscribing “Alice’s Diary” on its title page with a level of seriousness that marked the significance of the moment.

“Look, I’m done!” she declared, showcasing her work to Duncan. The letters were uneven but represented the best of her efforts since Duncan had taught her to read and write.

“Excellent,” Duncan commended with a smile, adding a gentle reminder, “Just remember, diaries are usually private. It’s important to keep them to yourself…”

Alice gestured towards Duncan’s diary with a puzzled face, “But you showed me yours.”

Caught in a moment of contradiction, Duncan’s face stiffened slightly as he explained, “…That’s because I’m aware you can’t decipher the contents.”

Feeling puzzled, Alice scratched her head and glanced down at her new diary with a mixture of uncertainty and concern, “Is it also not okay for you to see it?”

Duncan responded firmly, “Not okay,” emphasizing the privacy of a diary. However, seeing Alice’s troubled and somewhat disheartened look, he softened his stance, suggesting, “But if there’s something you really want to share with me, feel free to. Apart from that, I won’t peek; your secrets are your own.”

This reassurance brought a smile back to Alice’s face, “Okay!”

Duncan couldn’t help feeling a mix of amusement and exasperation at the situation, but he was glad to see Alice’s mood lift, which in turn lightened his own spirits.

Alice, not dwelling too deeply on the complexities of human emotions, was simply glad to see the captain in a better mood. She then changed the subject, her curiosity piqued about their upcoming journey, “Captain, are we heading to the border next?”

Duncan was caught off guard by her question.

Alice quickly clarified, “Miss Vanna told me,” eager to explain her source. “She mentioned we’re leaving in a few days and that we need to stock up on plenty of food and water because where we’re going might be very special…”

Acknowledging her information, Duncan confirmed, “Yes, it’s going to be a place unlike any other… a place I’m not entirely sure of myself, what it looks like, or what awaits us there.”

“Further than the Holy Island we visited before?”

“Much further than that.”

Alice’s “Oh~” was drawn out, her mind trying to grasp the concept of a destination even more distant and unknown than the Holy Island, but finding it difficult to visualize.

Duncan looked at Alice with intrigue, expecting perhaps a hint of worry or apprehension, but found none in her clear, untroubled gaze.

“Aren’t you scared?” he asked, probing for any sign of fear regarding the uncertainties of their expedition.

But Alice simply shook her head with conviction, dismissing any notion of fear.

Duncan decided to paint a grimmer picture to test her resolve further: “We could get lost beyond the border, face anomalies in time, and despite our best preparations, it might take a long time to return… if we can return at all.”

Yet, Alice’s response was to shake her head again, this time breaking into a reassuring smile, “Don’t worry, I’ll bring us back.”

“You? Bring us back?” Duncan couldn’t hide his astonishment and a touch of skepticism.

“Yes!” Alice’s confidence was unwavering.

“And how do you plan to do that?” Duncan asked, already anticipating her answer.

“I don’t know!” she replied cheerfully, without a hint of doubt.

Duncan was left speechless, looking at Alice, who radiated a bizarre confidence despite her confusion.

However, as he continued to observe her, his expression of bemusement gradually blended with a thoughtful gaze, as if Alice’s unfounded

confidence had sparked a new train of thought, mingling his helplessness with contemplation…

Chapter 764: Sailing into the Night

As the night stretched on, marking the twenty-second day since darkness had enveloped the world, a series of eerie and unsettling events began to unfold, as reported through messages from distant lands.

In the far-off Cold Port, an enormous shadow emerged momentarily above the sea, standing tall and imposing like a cliff yet appearing ethereal as fog. This shadow moved silently, gliding from the sea into the air, ominously advancing toward the city-state as if to envelop it in darkness. During the night, the shadow went largely unnoticed until the night watchmen, experiencing what they believed to be a watchful presence from above, triggered a panic that led to all the churches ringing their bells in unison. It was this clamor that seemingly scared the shadow away, making it disappear back into the darkness from whence it came.

Meanwhile, in the warmer climate of Mok, the entire lower district found itself engulfed in a bizarre fog of a crimson hue that carried a repulsive odor. The fog's arrival coincided with the malfunctioning of lights across several blocks, and this ominous mist even seeped into churches and night shelters for a brief period. It was only when the city-state's guardians managed to clear the fog, which had mysteriously formed during the night, that the affected districts reported several unnerving disappearances, including two technicians who had been out checking on the steam hubs.

From the Parman Islands, there were reports of a mysterious fleet suddenly appearing in the nearby waters under the cover of darkness, making its way toward the city-state. Despite being issued a no-docking command and

being directed to a designated waiting area, the fleet seemed perplexed by the ongoing “Long Night,” inquiring about the night with confusion and claiming it was experiencing “normal daylight” with “warm and bright sunshine” on their decks, even going so far as to question the sanity of the city-state’s inhabitants.

As the fleet disregarded the orders and continued its approach, the city-state’s navy was left with no alternative but to engage, resulting in the destruction of the unidentified ships amid a chaos of terrified screams, desperate curses, and pleas for help, leaving the sea littered with burning debris.

The nature of the ships the navy destroyed that night remained a mystery, as did the source of the “sunlight” they claimed to be basking in.

Now, on this twenty-second night of uninterrupted darkness, the world’s usual order is desperately clinging on, and the fragile semblance of “peace” is gradually eroding in this seemingly endless night.

In the lower district of Pland, outside Duncan’s antique shop, a gas street lamp cast a weak yellow glow, standing guard on the deserted streets where other lamps flickered with an almost imperceptible green flame.

Inside, Duncan was seated next to the shop window, meticulously cleaning a brass ornament while idly browsing through an old book.

The book was a treasure from Morris’s collection, a renowned work by the infamous “mad poet” Puman, cherished for its brilliance and madness alike.

On the page before him, Duncan admired the elegant cursive script that flowed across the paper:

“We shall have a long journey…”

While Duncan didn’t usually find the poetry of his world particularly captivating, the pervasive silence that had swallowed the city-state made

any distraction welcome, even the rhythmic beauty of verse.

It had been ages since the last customer had entered his antique shop. The stories behind each item in the shop seemed to have aged along with their physical forms, doubling in richness, and Duncan had resigned himself to the likelihood that this quiet would persist.

However, this solitude was abruptly interrupted by the sound of the door creaking open. The bell above it rang out clear and sharp, pulling Duncan from his thoughts. He lifted his gaze to the entrance and saw a man and a woman stepping into the light from the enveloping darkness outside, their movements tinged with a cautious nervousness.

"…How rare," Duncan observed them with a fleeting glance, noting their unmistakably human appearance, which piqued his curiosity, "to see people wandering about at this hour?"

The young man, evidently unsettled, adjusted his jacket and quickly surveyed the room before responding, "We noticed your lights were on… it seems every other place is locked up tight…"

"We're employed at the steam pump station and the power facility," the young woman chimed in hastily, her words laced with an eagerness that suggested they were eager to assert their reason for being out so late, "We carry passes that allow us to be here."

"Oh," Duncan responded with a nonchalant tone, setting aside the brass ornament he had been cleaning and regarding the two with a flicker of amusement in his eyes, "So, what brings you here? Looking to purchase something?"

"We were hoping to find a pair of porcelain plates, the decorative kind you might place on a mantelpiece," the young man said, quickly specifying, "… Nothing too pricey."

To Duncan’s surprise, they had come with a purpose.

Raising his eyebrows in mild intrigue, Duncan rose and made his way to a shelf, remarking over his shoulder, “This is an antique shop, so our items aren’t what you’d call cheap—though given the unusual circumstances, I’m willing to consider a discount, reducing the price from over four thousand to merely twenty-six…”

He paused, turning to look back at the couple with a curious gaze, “But I have to ask, why now? What I mean is, what’s the urgency of making such a purchase during these times?”

The couple shared a look, and the young woman offered a shy smile before replying, “We’re getting married.”

Surprise flickered across Duncan’s face at this revelation.

“We’re in the process of setting up our new home,” the young man elaborated, “and we wanted to add some decorative touches… With most places closed, we heard rumors of your shop remaining open and thought we’d take our chances here…”

“…To think, amidst this enduring darkness, I’d meet a pair of newlyweds,” Duncan murmured almost to himself as he selected a few ornate porcelain plates from the shelf, his voice tinged with wonder, “Why not wait for daylight to return?”

“What if daylight never returns?” the young man countered abruptly.

Duncan paused, turning to meet the young man’s gaze squarely.

“Now, with the future so uncertain… Our wedding was initially planned for the week before last, but we ended up delaying it until now. However, we’ve come to realize there’s no point in waiting any longer,” the young man explained, his voice carrying a mix of resolve and a hint of defiance against the unending night.

“Our ceremony will be a modest one, in compliance with the night’s curfew restrictions. We’ve arranged for the church’s priest to officiate at our own home. Should the sun choose to never grace us with its presence again…”

The young woman’s voice trailed off after she broached the grim possibility of an eternal darkness, her attempt at a smile betraying the effort it took.

Their words may have been simple, but the depth of their message was profound, echoing a sentiment that transcended eloquence: Life must continue, regardless of the circumstances. No amount of fear or lament could hasten the sunrise.

“Pick any that catches your eye,” Duncan suddenly offered with a warm smile, gesturing towards the illuminated shelves adorned with exquisite plates, each accompanied by a wooden stand for display.

After a moment of contemplation, the couple selected a pair of light green plates adorned with intricate golden patterns reminiscent of the craftsmanship of southern elves. They watched Duncan carefully wrap their choice in protective paper, and then, with a hint of timidity, the young woman inquired about the price.

“It’s on the house,” Duncan declared casually.

The surprise at his unexpected generosity was evident in the couple’s eyes.

“Let this be my wedding gift to you. The night may be long, but may this gesture bring a bit of luck your way,” he added, his voice imbued with a sincere wish for their happiness.

“But we couldn’t possibly…” the young man began, only to be interrupted.

“Don’t let time slip by; your pass has its limits,” Duncan gently reminded them with a smile, moving towards the door of the shop, “And don’t worry, you’ve already provided ample ‘compensation.’”

Puzzled, the young man asked, “Compensation? What do you mean?”

As Duncan opened the door, letting the light from the street lamps spill into the shop, he gestured towards the illuminated path that stretched into the night. “A moment of joy,” he said, sharing the source of his contentment.

With the couple gone, the shop once again surrendered to the quiet of the night. Duncan lingered at the doorway a moment longer, his sigh blending into the silence as he retracted his gaze from the street.

Meanwhile, at Wind Harbor, a different scene unfolded under a surreal, golden pseudo-sunlight.

The Vanished, with its towering masts, began to show signs of life as ethereal sails, as translucent as ghosts, billowed into existence. The exploration vessel leaned into its journey, departing from the harbor with a quiet dignity.

Not far off, the gleaming Bright Star activated its paddle wheels, the sound of the sea accompanying its departure.

“What’s making you so happy, Captain?” Alice asked with curiosity after noticing Duncan’s rare smile on the deck.

Turning away from the receding view of Wind Harbor, Duncan’s eyes lingered on the city-state they were leaving behind. With its myriad lights dimming into the distance and the faint, struggling sunlight fading from the coast, the island was gradually engulfed by the omnipresent shadow of the night.

Duncan took a moment before responding to Alice’s inquiry, his answer laced with a sense of optimism, “There are indeed moments of happiness to be found.”

Alice, still not entirely understanding but sensing the significance of his words, cast a lingering glance back towards the fading lights of the city-

state, her voice carrying a note of hope mixed with uncertainty, “Will we ever return there?”

In that brief pause, Duncan seemed to weigh countless thoughts and considerations about their impending journey, the myriad of paths that lay ahead, and the vast array of futures that could unfold from their decisions. Yet, he settled on a simple yet resolute affirmation: “…We’ll come back.”

This assurance brought a noticeable lift to Alice’s spirits.

Duncan, too, allowed himself a small smile at her reaction, then took a deep breath, easing his hold on the helm, symbolically letting go of the immediate concerns and focusing on the journey ahead.

They had now officially departed from Wind Harbor. Their next destination was the designated “rally point” on the eastern frontier, where they would join forces with the Storm Church’s border fleet. Together, they planned to navigate towards the Eternal Veil, tracing the path once charted by the Sea Song in a bold quest to uncover the truths that lay beyond the known world.

For Duncan, this expedition was more than a mere voyage; it was a crucial step in gaining a broader perspective on their world, to “observe this shelter from the outside,” and perhaps, to understand the larger forces at play.

However, before embarking on this grand adventure, there was a matter Duncan felt compelled to address directly.

He turned his attention to a solitary figure that seemed to shrink away at the edge of the helm, a gaunt and hunched presence trying to make itself as inconspicuous as possible.

“Sailor,” Duncan called out gently.

At the sound of his voice, Anomaly 077 stiffened, a mix of surprise and apprehension flashing across his features as he stammered, “Ah… Ah?!”

“Come here,” Duncan said, his voice warm and inviting as he took a step back to make room, gesturing towards the helm of the Vanished with an encouraging smile, “Take hold of it.”

Chapter 765: The Course

Suddenly, a sharp “crack” sound came from Sailor, startlingly indicating that a bone had just snapped out of place as the mummy twitched.

Then, Anomaly 077’s voice filled the air with dramatic pleas: “Captain! Captain, please, I beg you, don’t scare me like this! I promise I’m loyal, diligent, honest, and truthful! If I’ve made a mistake, just tell me, and I’ll correct it. There’s no need for this kind of intimidation… Or, if you prefer, you could just load me into a cannon and shoot me away…”

While begging, the mummy tried desperately to drag himself toward the ship’s railing as if he might throw himself over at any moment. He actually managed to swing his body over the railing, but before he could jump, a rope quickly shot out, wrapped around his ankles, and pulled him back onto the deck, tightly coiling around him.

Duncan approached with a half-smile that seemed more mocking than genuinely amused. He stopped a short distance away, simply watching.

Anomaly 077’s cries stopped suddenly. He shivered, pulled his neck in, and froze, eventually managing to say, “If you’re looking for entertainment, you might as well cook me… I could even do sit-ups in the pot for you…”

“There’s not a pot on board that’s big enough for you,” Duncan replied lightly, though his brief smile faded as he became more serious, “I’m serious, I have some experiments in mind.”

The change in the captain’s behavior and voice caught Anomaly 077’s attention, prompting him to look up at Duncan with a puzzled expression.

“…Experiments?”

“Release him,” Duncan said casually. The ropes, which seemed to have a life of their own, started unwinding from Anomaly 077, making a quiet rustling sound as they retracted.

Sailor, now standing and visibly confused, managed to fix his dislocated joint (explaining the “crack” noise Duncan heard earlier) and began to follow the captain, filled with both curiosity and worry. He eyed the ropes cautiously and approached the dark steering wheel but hesitated to touch it. After a moment of hesitation, driven by curiosity, he finally asked, “This experiment you’re talking about… what is it?”

“The course,” Duncan answered with indifference.

Sailor seemed to ponder for a moment, a hint of realization crossing his face.

“I know you don’t remember the course. Lucretia told me,” Duncan continued, locking eyes with Sailor, “but I trust the observations Captain Caraline recorded in her log. She believed that the experiences you’d have upon returning to the Boundless Seas would change you. She met the gods herself and was fundamentally transformed before she ‘recovered.’ She gained ‘knowledge’ that goes beyond what’s normally understandable.”

Duncan motioned towards Sailor as he spoke.

“Now, I need to understand ‘you’ and discover the truth behind your various ‘qualities.’ Just like Captain Caraline’s logbook that was found with you, I suspect you’re a kind of ‘medium.’ And for this experiment… letting you use your ‘power’ seems like the best way to get answers.”

Sailor looked down at his hands, pondering, “My power…”

With a tone of clinical curiosity, Duncan shared what he learned from the church’s documents about “Anomaly 077—Sailor’s” unpredictable abilities.

“When ‘Anomaly 077’ is active, it tends to ‘take over’ the nearest ship, causing it to teleport to random places in the Boundless Seas,” he explained, “and each teleportation brings the ship into a storm. This behavior particularly interests me.”

Sailor began to understand what the captain was suggesting. Looking at the helm, his hesitation was clear, “But if I actually touch the helm…”

“Don’t worry, the Vanished isn’t really affected by your powers. I just want to study how they work,” Duncan assured him casually, “and even if ‘teleportation’ and a ‘storm’ happen, it wouldn’t be much of a problem for this ship, nothing more than a breeze.”

“Uh, you misunderstood me,” Sailor quickly corrected, looking around anxiously, “I was worried the ship itself might fight back against me… I’ve noticed this ship seems to have elements that could start a fight easily. In just two hours on board, I saw at least three fights break out…”

As he spoke, Alice showed off her pride on the side.

Duncan’s face twitched when he saw the doll’s smug expression, “What are you so proud of!”

Alice proudly tilted her head, “I won my fight with the bucket!”

Duncan: “…”

Ignoring the doll’s strange behavior, Duncan refocused on Anomaly 077. “I’m in charge of everything on this ship, and I’m allowing you to take over the steering for now. Don’t worry about any negative consequences. But if you’re hesitant, I have another ‘research strategy’ we could use.”

Sailor immediately looked happier. “You have another plan?”

Duncan didn’t say anything but raised his hand, showing a small flame flickering at his fingertip.

Seeing this, Sailor’s excitement faded. “I think I prefer the first idea…”

Duncan flicked his finger, snuffing out the flame, and subtly motioned towards the steering wheel. “Go ahead and do what needs to be done before I change my mind and bring the flame back.”

Feeling resigned, Sailor took a deep breath, puffing out his chest as if drawing courage from the cool night air. He clenched his teeth, stepped forward, and with a decisive motion, reached for the steering wheel, his eyes closed.

The moment Anomaly 077’s withered, claw-like fingers touched the wheel of the Vanished, it was as if the first mate of the Sea Song was taking command of his ship.

Likewise, as soon as Sailor’s hand touched the wheel, Duncan heard a surreal, thunderous noise, like a huge ship launching into the ocean for the first time, surrounded by massive waves, with the sea itself shaking and breaking around the Vanished.

At that moment, the ship seemed to be caught in an unexplainable “force,” and Duncan felt this “presence” trying to take over the ship.

Normally, such a “presence” would have caused any regular ship to be swallowed by a dimensional rift, lost to some random location in the Boundless Seas where a storm would be taking place. However, the Vanished continued on its path across the waves, under Duncan’s careful command, immune to the mysterious force trying to alter its course.

Duncan’s concern grew as he felt an odd influence on the Vanished. Then, he suddenly sensed something out of the ordinary and looked around.

At that moment, a figure that blurred the lines between being there and not being there appeared in a corner of the bridge. Agatha emerged from the mirror realm, steadying herself on the railing with a sway. She looked at

Duncan, her expression a mix of confusion and worry. “Captain? What’s happening? The spirit world here is…”

Before she could finish, Duncan quickly closed the gap between them. “Agatha, I need your ‘eyes’.”

Caught by surprise, Agatha understood what he meant and reached towards her eyes. “Okay, just give me a second to take them out…”

Duncan, startled, quickly said, “Stop! You don’t have to do that!”

Confused, Agatha responded, “Ah?”

Duncan wasted no time in explaining further and conjured a spectral green flame, placing it gently on Agatha’s forehead.

“Just stay calm; it won’t hurt you.”

Before he could even assure her fully, the connection through the flame was established.

Now, Duncan could see through the gatekeeper’s eyes.

Suddenly, everything around Duncan seemed to shake briefly and intensely, as if the very light and shadows around him were shifting and realigning. Duncan’s vision flipped rapidly, then stabilized, giving him a unique view unlike any shared vision with Alice he had experienced before.

He found himself in a black-and-white world, looking up at the ghostly reflection of the Vanished in the “sky” above the sea. He saw unseen currents swirling violently at the edge of reality and illusion. In this strange, overlapping realm, he watched the sea’s surface in the distance continuously break apart and then reform.

In front of the Vanished, the sea acted like a faulty mirage, caught in a loop of breaking down and coming back together. Waves appeared and disappeared out of nowhere, and the entire surface of the sea would

suddenly vanish, leaving a huge “void,” only to fill back in and reappear seconds later. The scenery in the distance kept getting misplaced, and with each second, this pattern repeated as if stuck in a never-ending reset loop.

From the back of the mirrored Vanished, Duncan looked out at the ever-changing “landscape” before turning his attention to the helm.

There, a faint, nearly invisible figure could be seen holding the wheel, its features blurred and fading, like a lingering echo tied to the helm.

Next to Duncan, within this mirror world, Agatha appeared much more solid.

As she watched the incredible scene on the distant sea, she asked, “Captain, what are we seeing?”

“…It’s the course,” Duncan replied quietly, “the true path from the ‘border’ to the ‘outer barrier’ set by the gods.”

Agatha’s eyes widened in amazement.

“Duncan continued calmly, “As Captain Caraline noted in her log, she passed the course to her first mate. The course hasn’t disappeared,” Duncan explained, “Anomaly 077, he is the embodiment of the course.”

Again, the distant surface of the sea went through its cycle of breaking down and rebuilding, with a ghostly roar filling the sea as if resonating with the entire world.

“This phenomenon, which has been misunderstood as Anomaly 077 taking over and causing the ship to teleport randomly, is actually a form of guidance. It’s the Sea Song’s first mate trying to steer the ship towards the ‘destination’ ingrained in his memory. However, this effort could never succeed within the Boundless Seas, hence…”

He paused briefly, then added softly,

“Hence, the creation of those storms.”

Chapter 766: The Helmsman

Anomaly 077 turned out to be the key to unlocking the way to the external barrier, a secret cleverly hidden within his unique traits from the moment he was identified as an “anomaly.”

In the realms of the spirit world, the strange event of the sea collapsing and reforming around the Vanished continued without pause. Duncan and Agatha occasionally caught glimpses of a distant, alien landscape as if they were looking at an image flickering due to a weak signal. This phenomenon was fueled by the obsession linked to the “Sea Song,” which sought to guide those to their “final destination.”

However, in the Eternal Veil—a place known for its instability and isolation—Anomaly 077’s powers did not work as expected. As a result, the path he was meant to create became chaotic, misaligning time and building up a tremendous force with each failure.

When the energy finally achieved a spatial transition, this accumulated energy erupted in the real world, creating a violent storm as a consequence.

Duncan reached out towards the horizon, where flames began to spread across the sea’s surface. He had ignited the storm’s growing intensity, but he quickly extinguished it, causing it to vanish harmlessly into the air.

He then disconnected the “link” with Agatha and returned to the real world.

Sailor stayed at the ship’s helm, gripping the wheel tightly, his body tense as if he were about to break. When Duncan looked back at him, Sailor immediately said, “Captain, about me…”

Duncan nodded in acknowledgment: “You can let go now.”

Relieved, Sailor quickly stepped back from the wheel as if it were extremely hot, moving to the farthest corner from the helm. His behavior showed a mix of nervousness and fear. He cautiously watched the ropes and buckets around him, occasionally looking back at the wheel with a look of fear and awe.

Seeing Anomaly 077 in such a state, Duncan felt a rush of complex emotions. He remembered Captain Caraline amidst the chaos, the fleeting experience of steering the wheel in an alternate reality, and the Sea Song’s long, fragmented journey through time…

The mummy crouched in a corner of the helm, nervously looking around. It was as if the essence of the “First Mate,” who had survived the time-lost journey, had been stripped away, leaving behind only the captain’s log of the Sea Song and the “path” that had become part of him.

Duncan stayed silent for a while before softly sighing and approaching the wary Sailor.

“Captain, did I do my duty correctly?” Sailor asked cautiously, his voice filled with fear of not having met expectations and worried he might be asked to “steer the ship” again.

Duncan confirmed with a serious expression, “You have, this time,” looking Sailor in the eyes to convey the importance of his statement, “but this was just a preliminary test. As we go deeper into the Eternal Veil, I’ll need you to take on the role of helmsman again to officially guide us until we reach the destination once achieved by the Sea Song.”

Upon hearing Duncan’s words, Sailor’s already worried face seemed to sink even more. He instinctively tried to step back, only to realize the ship’s

railing was behind him. But the seriousness in Duncan's eyes made him stop.

Duncan spoke earnestly, "The Vanished depends on your guidance. You must realize the 'path' Captain Caraline left behind hasn't disappeared; it lives within you. You are the manifestation of that path—your unique 'abilities' and the supernatural occurrences you've initiated all originate from it. We need it now—I need your help."

Sailor paused, seeing the spectral figure of the captain before him in a different light, feeling a deep sense of purpose and value he hadn't felt in a long time.

"Can I really do it?" Sailor murmured, his voice filled with uncertainty, "This ship… it's not just something anyone can handle. I'm afraid it might overwhelm me the moment I try to steer it…"

Duncan reassured him with a steady voice, "You are more than capable of navigating this ship."

This statement left Sailor momentarily lost for words.

Duncan recognized the weight of such a task, "I know this is a heavy responsibility—very few people in the world would be brave enough to guide the Vanished without being crushed by the mental strain. But you, as the Sea Song's First Mate, have traversed beyond what most can imagine. You are qualified for this challenge," Duncan paused, then with a firm nod, he added, "If you accept, as the captain of the Vanished, I will formally name you our helmsman for this journey."

Duncan then mentioned, with utmost seriousness, "Of course, you're free to say no without any consequences. I'll find another way. If you prefer to go back to the White Oak now, that's also an option."

Sailor, clearly overwhelmed, considered his words carefully, wrestling with the decision amidst a flood of thoughts.

After a long moment, Sailor made up his mind. With a smile that was almost daunting, he nodded slowly, “Alright, I’ll do my best.”

As he spoke, the environment seemed to react—the ropes near the helm softly rustled, wooden barrels on the aft deck gently rocked, the sail ropes on the mast creaked quietly, and deep within the ship, the ancient structures whispered as if in conversation.

These noises blended together, creating a sound that felt like a welcoming round of applause.

Sailor took in the sounds with a mix of astonishment and confusion, his expression one of someone momentarily overwhelmed. Yet, as he understood what was happening, the deep lines on his face eased into a smile—a smile like the one he had when he first got promoted on the Sea Song years before.

Duncan, sharing the moment, smiled back and gently patted Sailor on the shoulder, comforting him, “Just do your best. That’s all we ask. Now, take some time to rest. We still have a long way to go before we reach our meeting point at the frontier.”

Looking slightly unsteady, Sailor left the helm and crossed the deck, his uneven steps disappearing into the night.

Duncan watched him leave and then turned back towards the middle of the deck, only to see Alice crouched near the helm, complaining to a coiled rope, “You didn’t welcome me with such excitement when I first came aboard… there was even applause now…”

The rope moved on the ground, extending a part of itself towards the railing as if trying to explain something.

“An induction ceremony for the helmsman? What is that?” Alice asked, her eyes wide with curiosity, “And what about me? Didn’t I get a ceremony too? It already happened? When?

“…Huh? The chaos in the kitchen was my ceremony!? Why didn’t anyone tell me earlier! I thought that was just a big mess… We almost destroyed the kitchen that day, and dinner was delayed because of it…”

Duncan, who was about to talk to Alice, stopped, watching her lively chat with the rope. He hesitated for a moment before awkwardly looking away, puzzled by her odd interactions with the ship’s inanimate objects.

As he reflected on this, he suddenly felt an intuition, hearing Goathead’s voice in his mind, “Captain, have you chosen a temporary helmsman?”

“Do you have any objections?” Duncan asked mentally as he walked back to the helm to navigate the Vanished further, “Are you worried about an ‘outsider’ taking on this role?”

“No,” Goathead quickly replied, “the captain has complete authority over the crew, including appointments or dismissals and creating or removing roles on the ship. The helmsman you support is the helmsman the Vanished recognizes, but… I am concerned about what destiny awaits ‘Sailor’ after he completes his duty.”

Duncan was silent for a moment, considering the consequences.

Goathead spoke again, this time more quietly than before, “It seems you’ve thought about this thoroughly. He was destined to be carried away by the currents of time, to vanish like the last sparks of a fire. On the day he returned to the Boundless Sea, he was meant to disappear. However, the log of Captain Caraline served as a shelter, preserving him, and the final journey of the Sea Song became a ‘path,’ grounding his existence. He became an eternal traveler…”

“Now, there’s only one last task for him—Captain Caraline’s final order.”

“And now, Captain, by making him the helmsman, you’ve given him the chance to fulfill his ultimate mission.”

In the cool night breeze at sea, Duncan looked out over the dark waters, pondering these thoughts for a while before finally speaking, “I understand, and, honestly, Sailor knows this too.”

Goathead remained silent, allowing the quiet to settle.

“Our voyage is still ongoing…”

Duncan then said softly, his mind recalling a book he had recently read, where the lines of a famous “mad poet” struck him, remembering from the text—

“Our journey is still ongoing until the moment when time itself comes to an end…”

…

The door to his cabin closed softly behind him, and the withered figure returned to the interior, easing onto his bed with careful, measured movements. The room was filled with warmth and light, sensations that had become unfamiliar to him over time.

As he lay there, he felt enveloped in a sense of coldness and isolation, with broken, scattered memories of the Sea Song passing through his thoughts as remote as if they belonged to another person.

He murmured to himself, repeating verses that had once been cherished by Captain Caraline—lines that shimmered in his faint memories like stars in the night sky above a desert:

“…Dusty sails shall rise again, leading us to lands long forgotten.”

“On the day destined for us, set forth fully ready…”

“We will all become explorers, embarking towards unseen lands with the wind at our backs.”

Sailor shifted in his bed, his dry, deformed eyes slowly closing.

Sleep continued to escape him.

Nevertheless, a slight smile appeared on his face.

The moment of truth was nearing.

Chapter 767: Border Base

Duncan found himself once again enveloped in the majestic fog that bridged the sky and the sea. However, this time his arrival at the frontier was shrouded in the secrecy of night, a stark contrast to his last visit. The sky above was a tumult of darkness, pressing down as if it could touch the world. The only light came from the eerie glow known as the World's Creation, which bathed the cloud edges and the fog wall in a pale, cold light. This massive fog barrier, visible through the night, seemed like a living entity—a dark, undulating mass that stood tall and distant. Its surface occasionally shifted to reveal unsettling, bizarre shapes, striking fear into the hearts of all who glimpsed it, evoking a primal dread.

The edges of this fog wall, touched by the light of the World's Creation, appeared to be adorned with countless eyes that stared down coldly and malevolently from the sky, overseeing the hubris of humans daring to explore the unknown ends of the world.

At the base of this imposing curtain of fog, human ambition had gathered in the form of fleets, poised on the brink of the unknown.

Upon sighting a distant lighthouse, Duncan commanded the Vanished, leading it to adjust their course slightly. Heading towards the southeast, they soon encountered the border—a massive, floating mobile port that sat atop the mist-enshrouded sea. It was a marvel of engineering, with its large steam core releasing plumes of white steam into the air and a differential machine's towering presence, its rotating lights occasionally slicing through the darkness to reveal the shadows of ships of various sizes nearby.

Surrounding the floating port were over a dozen ships, each distinct in design and size, while small patrol boats wove through the waters, their lights flickering in the darkness like fireflies dancing over an endless abyss.

Here, at the edge of the world, the usual rules of light discipline were abandoned, allowing these beacons of human presence to shine freely. They stood as a testament to humanity's persistence, a striking contrast to the vast and unfathomable sea and fog wall. Yet, brave as they were, these lights of civilization seemed almost inconsequential against the backdrop of the Boundless Sea and the towering fog, tiny specks that the ever-shifting fog could engulf at any moment.

In this world on the brink of collapse, these lights on the sea represented humanity's fragile yet defiant reach towards the crumbling edges of their sanctuary.

The arrival of the Vanished and the Bright Stars did not go unnoticed. Patrol vessels nearby quickly relayed their approach, and a welcoming steam whistle sounded from the mobile port, its echo carrying through the night. A beacon from the port's lighthouse then reached out across the sea, guiding the two ships to dock at the port's edge.

Once docked, Duncan led his crew onto the pier, where they were met by a gathering of figures there to welcome them. Among these figures, one in particular caught Duncan by surprise.

Pope Helena herself stood among the welcoming party of clergy, a sight that Duncan had not anticipated.

"Welcome to the 'Border Base'. We have been eagerly awaiting your arrival." Pope Helena took a step forward, her smile warm as she greeted Duncan and Lucretia, giving a slight nod in welcome.

Duncan, visibly taken aback by the sight of the High Priestess, couldn't hide his surprise. "How come you're here?" he asked. "Shouldn't you be on your ark right now? Can it really travel here so quickly?"

Helena's smile broadened at Duncan's question. "Should the need arise, the Church's ark can sail at speeds that rival your ship," she explained, her tone light. Yet, she quickly clarified, "But no, I'm not physically here. The Storm Cathedral remains at Wind Harbor. What stands before you is merely one of my avatars. It seemed fitting for me to personally send you off as you embark into the border."

Duncan's eyebrows arched in surprise at her revelation. The figure before him showed no obvious signs of being an illusion. "…Really can't tell," he admitted, impressed.

With a graceful motion, Helena raised her hand toward Duncan. Mist began to curl at the edges of her arm, and her skin turned as transparent as water, revealing the illusionary nature of her presence.

"Creating illusions in water and fog is a gift from my lord," she said, as her hand returned to its normal appearance and she started walking again. "This isn't considered a significant divine power—most high-ranking members of the Storm Church can perform it."

As Duncan followed Helena deeper into the border base, he glanced back at Vanna, who was trailing a bit behind. "Can you do this too?" he inquired, curiosity piqued.

Vanna hesitated for a brief moment before lowering her gaze, a hint of embarrassment in her voice. "Uh… actually…"

Before she could elaborate, Helena interjected from ahead, without needing to look back. "She can't," she stated plainly. "Despite my efforts to teach her, she never mastered it."

Vanna remained silent, her head still bowed in a mix of embarrassment and disappointment.

Shirley, who had been quietly following, seized the moment to tease, stepping closer to Vanna with a look of mock astonishment. “Hey, didn’t you claim your divine art skills were pretty decent?”

Caught in a moment of humiliation, Vanna felt compelled to defend her expertise, albeit reluctantly. “…Divine arts are vast, encompassing combat, healing, support, and several specialized fields like research, secrets, and miracles. I wasn’t proficient in all of them; my focus was quite specific…”

Half understanding yet curious, Shirley was about to guess, “Oh, so you’re skilled in combat…”

Still leading the way, Helena cut off the speculation without looking back. “She excels in healing,” she corrected, setting the record straight.

This revelation surprised not only Shirley but most of the group. Duncan, in particular, found himself reassessing Vanna, the formidable warrior beside him, trying to reconcile her prowess in battle with her proficiency in healing arts, a combination that seemed at odds with her formidable exterior…

In the typical portrayal, healing clergywomen are imagined in light cloth armor, clutching a short staff, positioned safely at the back of the battle formation due to their low defense and susceptibility to damage. They are the fragile lifelines that could perish with a single misstep. Then there’s Vanna, a figure capable of effortlessly overpowering demons single-handedly—how had she become associated with the role of a healer?

Duncan found himself grappling with this incongruity, though he kept his thoughts to himself, choosing not to voice the glaring question. However, the crew of the Vanished was not known for their reticence, often characterized by their direct and unfiltered curiosity.

“Why, though?” Shirley couldn’t hide her bewilderment, her gaze fixed on Vanna. Her confusion was palpable as she gestured towards Vanna’s imposing stature, her question trailing off into a puzzled, “…Why?”

Helena provided an answer with a nonchalant tone, “She became adept at setting bones on the training field after practice sessions,” revealing that Vanna had mastered this aspect of healing in merely six months.

Shirley’s puzzled expression dissolved into understanding, and even Duncan found himself nodding, albeit with a complex mix of emotions, “… That makes more sense.”

Vanna, the subject of their discussions, remained silent, her head bowed, lost in thought.

Duncan, however, was struck by another realization. “But you’ve been with us on the ship for so long, and I’ve hardly seen you perform any healing. Why is that?” he inquired, looking at Vanna with a thoughtful expression.

Vanna’s response was laced with a hint of resignation, “Do you think anyone on the Vanished actually needs healing?”

Duncan paused, considering her words. He looked around at his crew, realizing the unique composition of the Vanished’s occupants—predominantly non-living beings, making the necessity for a healer somewhat redundant. The only somewhat human figure, old Morris, was renowned for his resilience, seemingly more durable than many saints…

Vanna sighed once more, her gesture towards her greatsword and the clasp on her shoulder speaking volumes. “I think it’s better this way—preventing harm by eliminating threats before they can cause injury. That way, nobody has to suffer.”

Helena’s gaze then shifted to Anomaly 077, who lingered at the back of the group. She slowed her pace, giving the mummy a contemplative look

before posing a question, “Do you remember this place?”

Sailor’s response was calm and measured, indicative of his complex relationship with his memories. “I remember, but it’s vague,” he admitted. Despite having regained some of his memories, including those of this very location, they felt detached, as if belonging to someone else. “Even the deepest memories seem foreign, except for those involving Captain Caraline,” he concluded, reflecting on the peculiar nature of his recollections.

Helena’s voice was gentle, refraining from delving deeper into the extent of Sailor’s recollections or his emotional connection to the place. It was a delicate acknowledgment of the chasm between Anomaly 077’s past life as the Sea Song’s first mate, a role he played until not so long ago, and his current existence as a distant echo of that life. For the port’s guards, the transition might seem recent, but for Sailor, it was a chapter from another lifetime.

“You’re essentially a stranger here now,” Helena reassured Sailor, her words offering comfort. “Aside from myself and a select few within the Church’s higher echelons, no one knows of your current appearance. You needn’t fret over bumping into old ‘friends’—unless you wish to, of course.”

Sailor appeared caught off guard by Helena’s assurance, his response carrying a tone of genuine gratitude. “Thank you,” he said, bowing his head slightly in appreciation.

It was at this juncture that Lucretia’s curiosity bubbled to the surface. “Has this port always operated in the border region?” she inquired. “My own ventures have taken me near these waters, yet I’ve never come across it…”

Helena provided a comprehensive overview of the port’s history and function. “This mobile port has anchored the border waters for the better

part of a decade," she began. "However, the dense fog that blankets this region often obscures its presence. It serves a dual purpose: as a border patrol and exploration fleets base. It's also a hub for research. Equipped with extensive laboratories and observational equipment, it delves into the mysteries of the spirit world and the marine ecosystem. Its missions often necessitate ventures deep into the fog. When not on a specific assignment, it patrols the eastern border. Its movements and stops are cloaked in secrecy by the Church. It's no surprise that you've never stumbled upon it."

Lucretia expressed her admiration for the port's operations and its role in the border waters, "…Impressive."

Helena echoed the sentiment, her voice tinged with a mix of pride and nostalgia. "Yes, it is indeed impressive. This place was forged by the collective efforts of many remarkable people." Her gaze then drifted towards a point in the distance, lost in thought for a moment. "The Sea Song, it set sail from Dock No. 2, right over there," she noted, pointing out the location with a hint of wistfulness.

Chapter 768: The Black Fog

At the historic location where the Sea Song once embarked on its journey, the dock now stands deserted. The ship had found its way back through an accidental journey to 1675, but it’s clear that it can never return to this spot again.

“I remember this place too…” Sailor whispered, his gaze fixed on the pier that was now bathed in the bright glow of powerful lights. The docks, extending from the movable harbor, seemed like the sprawling limbs of a colossal creature, each stretching out towards the infinite expanse of the night sky. In this remote area, far from the glow of city lights, stepping beyond the illuminated docks felt like venturing into oblivion—a leap into the dense, dark fog that required immense bravery.

“We’ve got three escort ships lined up for you. They’ll act as guides,” Helena explained. “Once they’re all set, they’ll accompany you through the fog and lead you to the ‘lighthouse,’ the last known location from which the Sea Song transmitted its signal. From that point, you’ll push forward, crossing the six mile limit. The three battleships, serving as your navigational guides, will remain near the lighthouse, awaiting your return.”

Duncan responded with a silent nod. Fueled by curiosity, Lucretia inquired, “How long will you wait for us here?”

“Indefinitely,” Helena replied with a light tone. “The era of pioneering patrols is coming to an end. The Eternal Veil is slowly disintegrating, leading to an increase in ships encountering strange and perilous mutations. Most of the patrol paths have become impassable. As a result, aside from

maintaining some critical observation points, the patrol fleets are withdrawing to safer areas within the Boundless Sea. This movable port and my presence here will remain until you return. Or…" She trailed off, then took a deep breath and fixed her gaze on Duncan, expressing her hope for their safe return.

"We'll make it back safely," Duncan assured her confidently, his arms crossed as he stared out at the foggy horizon. "Both the Vanished and the Bright Stars have managed to return from beyond that boundary, and now, with Captain Caraline's 'map,' nothing will prevent our return."

Helena gave a slight nod in acknowledgment.

Following this exchange, Duncan and his team finalized their preparations at the frontier outpost. When the three escort ships, designated as their navigational guides, were ready, they embarked on their journey. It was a moment that would blend into the countless others in the vast expanse of the night, marked by the resounding farewell whistle from the movable port.

Three modern warships adorned with the emblem of the Storm Church, accompanied by two ancient "ghost ships" that had witnessed a century, departed from the dock. As they moved further away, the bright illumination of the port dimmed, leaving them enveloped by the thickening night. The dense fog, alive under the cover of darkness, turned an even deeper shade of black, exerting a formidable pressure that seemed almost alive.

Standing on the ship's elevated stern deck, Duncan couldn't help but cast his gaze back towards the port. As they moved further away, the bright lights of the port began to fade into the distance. In this moment of transition, Duncan recalled the parting words of the Cretan he once met—advising him to "walk against the light."

This notion of moving against the light wasn’t new; the Doomsday Survey Team had embraced this approach, as had the Sea Song during its historic departure from this very port. Now, it was the turn of the Vanished and the Bright Stars to embark on this challenging path.

Following those who dared to confront the unknown, each venture against the light represented a step deeper into the unexplored. Now, the crew of the Vanished was on the cusp of reaching the true “beyond” of their world.

Standing beside Duncan, Alice was visibly fascinated by the ominous fog ahead. The closer they got, the more she craned her neck upwards, eventually expressing her astonishment with a mix of fear and wonder, “Wow… it’s even scarier than during the day… bah.”

Predictably, as she looked up beyond a certain angle, her doll head came off. Duncan, without even looking, caught Alice’s head by the hair and brought it in front of him, slightly annoyed, “When will you ever learn…”

With her eyes blinking, Alice protested, “Captain… don’t grab the hair… hair falling out…”

Nonchalantly, Duncan handed back Alice’s head, which she quickly reattached to her neck. She then noticed a single strand of hair had come loose, which she held sorrowfully, lamenting, “Another one… poor Kalenifoskina Portitas Angwenistan Leforgen IV…”

Duncan, caught off guard by the elaborate name, asked incredulously, “… Have you started naming them that outrageously?”

Alice remained silent, her head bowed as she twirled the strand of hair with a somber expression.

Observing this, Duncan cautioned her, “…Be careful not to get it stuck in your finger joints. Last time, it was quite the task to clear the hair from your joints.”

While they exchanged these words, Duncan's attention returned to the "Eternal Veil" that was beginning to envelop the bow of the Vanished. He noticed something peculiar—the fog was becoming darker, not just from the absence of light, but its very essence seemed to be shifting in color.

Under normal circumstances, fog, even at night, would appear lighter in color and become more visible when lit. The stark darkness of this fog hinted at something unnatural.

Concerned, he promptly communicated with Vanna, who was positioned on the forward deck, asking her to check on this anomaly. Vanna quickly relayed information from the leading ships through their mental link.

"The color of the fog has been gradually changing over the past two days," Vanna informed him, "notably after the Sea Song ventured beyond the six-mile mark. However, this alteration is only on the surface; deeper within the fog, its color remains lighter, as expected."

She briefly paused, apparently still in mental communication with her colleagues at the church for further details, before adding, "The scholars have conducted numerous examinations. Other than the alteration in the color of the surface layer, these dense fogs have remained unchanged—there's no presence of toxins… It's as though only the 'color' attribute is affected in this superficial layer…"

Hearing Vanna's update, Duncan's face took on a contemplative seriousness, nodding slowly as he watched the dark fog increasingly shroud the bow of the Vanished.

In response to the growing darkness, all ships in the fleet reduced their speed and activated various warning and navigation lights along their structures. The Vanished, the escort ships, and the Bright Stars tightened their formation, carefully maintaining a safe distance from one another to prevent any mishaps. The visibility around them diminished rapidly,

necessitating this close formation to ensure that no ship strayed or collided with another.

Surrounding the Vanished, ethereal flames of a ghostly green hue began to emerge, casting a spectral light. These spirit fires seemed to cut through the dense, dark fog, faintly illuminating the shapes of nearby ships amidst the swirling mists.

The black fog that enveloped the fleet moved like living, undulating veils, creating a surreal atmosphere around the ships.

After setting the green flames ablaze, Duncan remained focused on the fog, his brow furrowed in thought. Abruptly, he headed towards the captain's quarters.

"Umm, Captain, where are you going?" Alice called out, puzzled by his sudden departure.

"Just stepping away for a moment," Duncan replied with a casual wave, "Don't worry, I'll be back shortly."

As he moved, he mentally signaled his first mate: "Goathead, you're in charge of the Vanished. I need to step out for a bit. If we reach the six-mile mark and I haven't returned, inform the others to hold position."

"Understood, captain."

Duncan quickly arrived at the door to the captain's quarters. Before him stood the enigmatic "Door of the Lost," silent and imposing as always.

He inhaled deeply, then pushed the door open, stepping through.

The transition was marked by a cool breeze and a brief moment of disorientation, a sensation now familiar to him. Zhou Ming found himself back in his modest bachelor apartment, the window revealing the perpetual gray-white fog that obscured the world beyond his small dwelling.

This time, however, Zhou Ming didn’t head towards the window to peer outside. Instead, he turned to observe the path he had just taken.

The main door of the apartment stood ajar, revealing the surging black fog outside. This was not the first time he had encountered it; on the day he had first chosen to step through this door, the same black fog had greeted him—it was this very fog that had served as a conduit from his “shelter” to the Boundless Sea, marking the beginning of his journey aboard the Vanished.

Zhou Ming’s expression deepened with concern as he pondered a mystery that had intrigued him—why was it that the fog obscuring the world outside his windows was a benign gray-white, yet the fog that lingered outside his apartment’s main entrance bore an ominous shade of black?

Now, this same unsettling black fog had begun to manifest at the edges of the Boundless Sea.

Could this phenomenon be a harbinger of impending doom? A sign that the barriers between worlds were weakening? Or perhaps it signified that from the moment he dared to traverse the black fog, his fate was intertwined with a pivotal moment on the brink of the end?

The Sea Song, in its return to the Boundless Sea lacking precise “navigation,” was misplaced into the year 1675. However, when Zhou Ming stepped through the black fog, he was transported directly to the Vanished in the year 1900—eerily close to what felt like the eve of the world’s end.

“Beyond the six-mile boundary, time loses its continuity…”

“Without precise ‘navigation,’ the point in time one arrives at when re-entering the Boundless Sea through the six-mile threshold is unpredictable…”

“There must be some way to determine the ‘time landing point’ with accuracy…”

Zhou Ming whispered to himself, attempting to organize his jumbled thoughts. After a moment, he began to move towards the room.

However, as he walked past the window, he abruptly stopped.

Out of the corner of his eye, he caught sight of something on the window glass.

There, etched in faint, mist-like, mirror-reversed script, was a line of text.

At this discovery, Zhou Ming’s sense of astonishment and disbelief surged. He stood frozen for a brief second, then swiftly moved to the window as if propelled by a sudden gust of wind!

Chapter 769: Visitor in the Mist

After hurrying to the window, Zhou Ming was able to confirm, much to his astonishment, that what he had seen was indeed real—there were actual words written on the window! Even more intriguing was the fact that these words were inscribed from the outside, using the widely recognized language of the city-states.

The appearance of the words was peculiar; they seemed to quiver slightly on the glass, creating an unsettling effect. It was as if they weren't directly etched onto the firm, unyielding surface of the window but rather appeared to be suspended in a sort of ephemeral, mist-like illusion. Zhou Ming had to concentrate intensely on these letters for a considerable duration before he could decipher the message from the indistinct and reversed script—

"I am outside. You are inside."

This revelation left Zhou Ming utterly bewildered—he couldn't fathom why anyone, or anything, for that matter, would go to the lengths of leaving such a seemingly simplistic and cryptic message on the exterior of his "shelter cocoon."

At first, he couldn't help but find the situation somewhat amusing, yet a moment later, his amusement gave way to contemplation as a vague idea began to form in his mind.

Zhou Ming gradually moved away from the window, casting his gaze towards the gray-white fog that shrouded the exterior.

He had been attempting to piece together what lay beyond his “apartment” with only vague guesses up until this point. While the finer details eluded him, he had started to discern a certain pattern or, more precisely, a fundamental logic underlying the deepest essence of this world.

He realized that the notion of “information” carried profound significance; the way information is conveyed lays the groundwork for order. Building on this realization, he understood that “symbolism” in this realm possessed a tangible and potent… “function.”

With this epiphany, Zhou Ming looked back at the text, his perception subtly shifting. He began to suspect that the phrase wasn’t simply meant for “communication” with him.

Instead, it served as an “anchor point”—a marker placed by some entity that comprehended and had the power to manipulate the “truth” of their reality, marking its presence outside his room.

Suddenly, Zhou Ming’s train of thought was interrupted by a recollection: the mysterious knocking sound that emanated from the black mist during his last return to this place!

In the next instant, as if his memories had the power to influence reality itself, the moment this thought crossed his mind, a sound abruptly emerged beside him—bang, bang, bang.

Zhou Ming quickly turned towards the apartment’s door, only to realize that the sound wasn’t emanating from there. The knocking was coming from the window, suggesting the presence of an unseen visitor outside, obscured by the gray-white fog, persistently tapping on the glass, invisible yet undeniably there, as if awaiting recognition from the “little house’s” inhabitant.

This scenario inexplicably made Zhou Ming think of those “fish.”

Zhou Ming approached the window once more, this time placing his hand against the glass where the knocking originated in an effort to both feel and hear more distinctly—the knocking persisted, and slowly, he began to sense an actual vibration transmitting through his palm.

Lifting his gaze, he peered into the dense fog outside, engaging in a silent confrontation with the “visitor” obscured within it. He envisioned a guest, a being that, among all conceivable possibilities and logical paths, “might possibly manifest here.”

Who could it be, reaching out to him from the very edge of order, from a realm nearly severed from all other existences, at the very foundation of reality itself?

A shadowy figure briefly materialized within the mist, and just as this shadow came into view, Zhou Ming sensed a familiar essence piercing through the dense veil—a spark of his own, a blast from the past he presumed lost forever.

This realization instantly validated his perceptions; the “visitor in the mist” materialized into a definitive presence.

Abruptly, the gray-white mist dissipated, and the once perpetual “landscape” outside transformed in an instant into a brightly lit, elegantly furnished room—a stark contrast to the view from his side of the window. Across this newly revealed setting stood a woman with silver hair cascading over her shoulders, her eyes wide in astonishment at the dramatic shift unfolding before her.

“Ali…” Zhou Ming found himself uttering instinctively at the sight of her, but he quickly corrected himself, “No, Ray Nora—is it really you?!”

With this acknowledgment, the truth ushered in a directed collapse, and the view outside the window solidified.

There stood the Frost Queen Ray Nora, the enigmatic “visitor in the mist.” Now, she continued to gaze intensely at Zhou Ming—or more precisely, at an unfathomable presence enveloped within some vast, chaotic expanse.

Her eyes mirrored the infinite depths of distant galaxies, their light piercing through the “glass” into her surroundings, casting a subtle celestial glow over what was once a part of “Alice Mansion’s” bedroom, as if it were on the verge of being engulfed by the cosmos itself.

However, under Zhou Ming’s watchful eye, Ray Nora’s expression suddenly shifted, as if she had managed to shake off the mesmerizing effect of the cosmic light, regaining her clarity. She attempted to speak, but through the barrier of the window, only indistinct sounds could be heard.

“…I see… light…”

Zhou Ming, driven by an urge to comprehend her words fully, instinctively pushed the window open.

He remained motionless, staring in disbelief at the now open window, taking a moment to grasp the reality of the situation—the window had indeed opened!

After an interminable duration, during which the dense fog had enveloped this room, rendering it seemingly inaccessible, the window had unexpectedly swung open with startling ease. Zhou Ming was momentarily paralyzed by disbelief, struggling to process the ease with which the barrier between him and the outside world had been dismantled.

Regaining his composure, his attention was immediately captured by the figure of “the Frost Queen” Ray Nora, stationed across from him.

For Ray Nora, witnessing the barrier of light that she had been facing suddenly give way was beyond astonishing; it was an event that defied all expectations in her “drifting journey” across realms. To encounter an entity

endowed with “intellect”—perhaps even “humanity”—at the very edge of time and space was a revelation that shattered all her conceptions of the universe.

Despite the overwhelming chaos of starlight that obscured any definitive shape, making it impossible to discern any logic or reason within that bewildering expanse, she intuitively recognized the intelligence behind it. It had heeded her call, unveiling a portion of its enigmatic domain. A “limb” now extended towards her, adorned with millions of eyes that flickered and emitted a discordant sound.

“It’s really you,” Zhou Ming expressed his astonishment upon seeing “Her Majesty the Queen” again, grappling with his confusion. “You’ll have to wait a moment, I’m a bit confused… How did you find yourself here? You departed from Alice’s Mansion, and since then, you’ve been… wandering at the fringes? Was it you who knocked last time?”

The cacophony among the stars was overwhelming, yet amidst the turmoil, Ray Nora’s clarity was being incessantly reforged. She watched the “limb” oscillate before her, the myriad voices at its end clamoring for her attention, but gradually, she began to decipher their message.

She realized she was beginning to comprehend the whispers of the cosmos—they were inquiring about her quest.

“I’m on a journey,” she responded instinctively, recounting her odyssey. “I was adrift in the spirit realm, then caught in the currents of subspace… At the edge of all existence, I found myself ensnared by the mist. Yet, a beacon of light emerged, guiding me here, to this grand ‘hall’…”

Ray Nora paused, stepping back to fully appreciate the structure before her that appeared to transcend time itself—a “cocoon” suspended at the brink of oblivion, its duration in this liminal space unknown, now revealing a sliver of itself. An ancient and profound presence communicated with her through

this opening, each utterance, each vibration laden with truths so profound they could unravel the mind a thousand times over.

Yet, amidst this confrontation with the unfathomable, she found herself gaining steadiness, becoming resilient enough to withstand the onslaught of these cosmic truths. Her mind, too, began to anchor itself more firmly amidst the chaos.

Ray Nora found herself unexpectedly adapting to the situation, regaining her sense of logic and clarity after what could only be described as a reckless encounter with the unknown. It hadn't even dawned on her that her own voice had taken on a vibratory quality, echoing the tumultuous interaction, nor had she realized how the intense luminescence of starlight had become a permanent fixture in her field of vision.

"You fell into subspace?" Zhou Ming expressed his astonishment with a frown, noting the peculiar tone in Ray Nora's voice as she responded. Despite sensing something off about her condition, he didn't dwell on it too much. Instead, he scrutinized her for any signs of subspace contamination, half-jokingly lamenting, "…Why does it seem like everyone's been taking subspace dips lately…"

Feeling somewhat bewildered by the ongoing stir within her soul, Ray Nora couldn't grasp the significance of the new tremors. Yet, amidst this confusion, she began to perceive a more coherent "entity" amidst the chaotic swirl of starlight and the extending "limb." It appeared as though a figure was standing within that vast and impressive "nest."

With a slight tilt of her head and a furrowed brow, she ventured, "Are you inviting me in?"

Zhou Ming was caught off guard by her question—had he extended an invitation?

Shaking off the momentary confusion, he embraced the idea. Having been isolated in this secluded “cage” for so long, the prospect of entertaining a guest was genuinely appealing. He hadn’t anticipated company, but now that the opportunity had arisen, he found the idea rather pleasant.

Feeling somewhat sheepish, he glanced down at the windowsill and chuckled awkwardly, “Then you’ll have to climb through the window… I’m not quite sure how to usher you in through the door…”

In response, the supernatural presence made way for her; the fissure in the cosmic “nest” widened as if opening its doors, and the light, brimming with truth and enlightenment, beckoned her forward.

Without a second thought, Ray Nora advanced towards the beckoning light.

As Zhou Ming observed her bold, unhesitant approach through the window, he was struck by the realization of why she had been the one to spearhead the deep dive project decades earlier. Her determination and decisiveness far surpassed that of the average individual.

Nonetheless, he couldn’t resist cautioning her, “Hey, be careful, don’t fall…”

Ray Nora transitioned through the window, her surroundings undergoing a dramatic transformation.

And then, with a solid impact, Her Majesty the Queen landed on the floor. “Ouch!”

Chapter 770: The Visiting Frost Queen

The atmosphere in the room was momentarily filled with silence.

Zhou Ming chose not to break the quiet, feeling that any words spoken in this peculiar situation might only serve to make things more uncomfortable than they already were.

Similarly, the Frost Queen remained silent as well, continuing to lie on the floor, making no attempt to get up.

In this way, the two of them found themselves in a strange sort of standoff. The Frost Queen was busily engaged in chewing on the floor, while Zhou Ming, unable to tear his gaze away, found himself fixated on the back of her head. This unusual scene persisted for about thirty seconds until Zhou Ming felt compelled to intervene. It simply didn’t seem proper to watch silently as a lady gnawed at the floor.

Gently bending over, he cautiously broke the silence, asking, “…Do you need help getting up?”

Ray Nora experienced a sudden shift in her perception. The incessant buzzing, the cacophony that had filled her mind, abruptly clarified into coherent human speech, understandable without the need for focused effort. This unexpected clarity prompted her to react swiftly, propelling herself off the floor with force.

In the process, her head collided with Zhou Ming's chin, a painful encounter that preempted any vocal reaction from her before she found herself once again in her initial position on the floor.

Zhou Ming, taken aback by her sudden movement, momentarily saw a burst of stars in his vision.

Quickly shaking off the disorientation, he ignored the lingering stars before his eyes and moved to assist the "Queen" who had stumbled once more, apologizing with a hint of awkwardness, "Sorry, I was standing in the wrong place… Are you okay?"

Despite the buzzing in her head, Ray Nora felt unprecedented clarity. She realized that her reasoning faculties had fully re-engaged, and a complex "understanding" had reassembled in her mind. This newfound clarity allowed her to perceive the surrounding chaos in a new light, revealing another aspect of this "nest."

She observed the room's floor, tables, chairs, and various other objects that seemed ordinary to humans, all suspended in a vast expanse of dimly lit darkness. This space seemed to be bordered by walls of illusion, perpetually expanding and contracting in her vision, creating an effect similar to a series of mimicked illusions.

This perception led her to feel as though some unnamed, non-human presence inhabited this space, expertly imitating human characteristics and surroundings.

She also noticed the "entity" that had spoken to her. Although it appeared as a bewildering array of stars, these stars now formed a vaguely human silhouette. While she couldn't discern any facial features within the radiant starlight, she could see the "hands" that were supporting her arms, and she heard the starlight articulate in a human voice, conveying a sense of friendliness and kindness.

“I… am okay,” Ray Nora responded, her voice tinged with hesitation. Despite the wisdom and poise typically associated with the Frost Queen, she appeared somewhat bewildered by the series of unforeseen events. Seeking to engage with this “entity” that seemed to emulate human behavior, she apologized, “Sorry for disturbing your peace, I was merely… curious, and then this curiosity ensnared me in your ‘palace’…”

Zhou Ming’s brow furrowed slightly, sensing something peculiar in the manner in which the Frost Queen addressed him. However, he didn’t dwell on this feeling for long, as he was equally bewildered by the situation—the vision of stars swirling before his eyes hadn’t yet cleared, and he could only manage a vague gesture with his hand, saying, “It’s okay, I never imagined… you would be the first ‘human’ to visit this place.”

Driven by her escalating curiosity, Ray Nora gestured towards a spherical object hovering near what could be assumed to be the entity’s head, given the constellation of stars forming its semblance, and inquired, “…What is this?”

Zhou Ming glanced upwards, his face momentarily adopting a contemplative silence before he attempted to grasp the small celestial body, which was enveloped in a faint yellow hue, seemingly detached from his own essence. Upon his touch, the miniature planet silently merged back into him.

“This is Venus,” he explained, striving to maintain a neutral expression and tone, “a… star.”

Ray Nora observed this vision with wide-eyed wonder, spontaneously reacting with, “…Incredible.”

“I also find it incredible,” Zhou Ming admitted earnestly, “Before you collided with me, I could never have envisioned… such an event occurring.”

He then looked down at his hands, which appeared normal, but as he focused, imagining the cosmos, faint stars began to materialize before his eyes. His transformation seemed to deepen…

Puzzled by the “stellar entity’s” actions, Ray Nora was simply astonished that it exhibited human-like intelligence, marveling at the fact she was engaging in conversation with such a remarkable being at the world’s edge. Feeling reassured by the entity’s friendly demeanor, she ventured more boldly, “Have you… always resided here?”

Zhou Ming’s frown deepened as he suddenly identified the subtle oddity in Ray Nora’s way of speaking.

“You don’t recognize me?” he queried, his surprise evident.

“Recognize you?” Ray Nora responded, her gaze filled with confusion as she looked at the non-human figure, “Have we… met previously?”

After a brief pause, Zhou Ming had a realization—of course, Ray Nora had never actually seen him before.

She had encountered Duncan.

Thus, he opened his palm, summoning forth a flame for Ray Nora to see.

A greenish flame emerged amidst the stars, establishing a connection instantly—the flicker of flame that Ray Nora had previously encountered resonated with the one now before her.

“Do you remember now?” The constellation of stars vibrated as it communicated in human speech.

Ray Nora was momentarily paralyzed by the revelation, taking several seconds to regain her composure before looking at Zhou Ming in utter disbelief: “You are… the Captain?!”

“…That’s one aspect of my being,” Zhou Ming reflected, attempting to clarify for the “Queen” his multifaceted nature, “Or rather, one of my forms, a vessel.”

He paused for a moment, then felt compelled to share his thoughts: “You are the first ‘human’ to witness me in this form, now you’re privy to a secret unknown to others.”

A wave of profound realization surged through Ray Nora’s consciousness, akin to the overwhelming awe she experienced upon her first encounter with the enigmatic “cocoon” – a seismic shift in her understanding, revealing truths previously concealed!

Yet, perhaps due to her prior venture through the “crack” into this “cocoon” and enduring an initial awakening, the disorientation this time was fleeting. She swiftly regained her cognitive clarity and pieced everything together—

She had stumbled upon an enigmatic force at the edge of existence, a confluence of countless forms, an entity whose “tentacles” reached into the fabric of reality itself, manifesting in myriad ways yet stemming from a singular origin. This origin lay dormant at the end of all time, and now she, a daring explorer, had uncovered it.

“We haven’t seen each other for a long time,” Zhou Ming remarked with a smile, aware that the revelation would momentarily disorient Ray Nora, yet noting her prolonged daze, he felt compelled to engage her in conversation, “Don’t just stand there, come sit down. Tell me about your adventures after you ‘escaped,’ how you discovered my ‘little abode,’ and what those symbols you were tracing outside mean.”

With that, he made his way to the sofa.

“Don’t be put off by the simplicity here. After the apocalypse, resources are scarce, and this place can’t hold a candle to the grandeur of your former

palace or your opulent bedroom now—and there's little here for entertainment. But then, as a ghost now, you probably don't have much use for food, do you?"

"Uh… no, no need."

Ray Nora responded almost reflexively, still somewhat in a trance as she followed Zhou Ming to the sofa. Her steps were uncertain, as if the ground beneath her shifted and undulated, sparking Zhou Ming's curiosity: "Feeling dizzy?"

Internally, Ray Nora lamented: everything in this realm hovered in a state of perpetual flux, hardly a stable environment for mortals, hence the dizziness was to be expected.

However, she hesitated to voice this complaint in front of the "stellar entity," instead bravely admitting, "A bit, but it's manageable."

"…Oh, then please, take a seat quickly."

Zhou Ming suggested, his tone reflecting a hint of concern as he touched his nose, musing over the fact—the "Queen" had indeed suffered a couple of harsh falls to the floor, quite forcefully at that… It appeared those impacts were not trivial.

Yet, he didn't dwell on guilt—he too had been struck hard enough to see stars.

Once seated on the sofa, Ray Nora found her surroundings marginally more stable.

Though the "sofa" itself was shrouded in an enigmatic dark mist, its surface pulsating with a vibrant "hue" reminiscent of a living organism, at least seated, she was spared the disorienting sensation of traversing through chaos.

Zhou Ming took a seat on an adjacent sofa, his gaze filled with curiosity as he regarded the Frost Queen, long lost to time: “Alright, now share the tale of your journey.”

“…After I managed to escape from that confining space, I’ve been navigating through the intricacies of time and space,” Ray Nora began, succinctly capturing the essence of her adventures post her escape from what she referred to as “Alice’s mansion with her bedroom.” “The journey I undertook was nothing short of peculiar. As I mentioned earlier, it even involved traversing the disturbances within subspace—my ‘little house’ served as a sort of sanctuary, shielding me as I ventured through these chaotic, fragmented passageways that exist beyond the conventional dimensions of our reality…”

“My travels were laden with remarkable occurrences, tales of which I’m eager to share with you later. However, what might capture your interest at this moment is the manner in which I stumbled upon this location…”

“To summarize the experience, I was inadvertently drawn here by a sudden current. After enduring a prolonged period of entrapment, the beacon that initially directed me to your home was… a lamp.”

“…A lantern?!” Zhou Ming reacted, his eyes growing wide in astonishment.

“Indeed, a lantern, adrift in the mist,” Ray Nora affirmed with earnestness, “Specifically, a lantern of the type commonly used aboard vessels.”

Chapter 771: Ray Noras Journey

The atmosphere in the Nest became eerily quiet for a brief moment, so much so that the constant, low-grade tremors that usually echoed between the stars seemed to pause. Ray Nora noticed the humanoid figure in front of her freeze, almost as if her words had put it into a temporary state of suspension. Then, after what felt like an eternity, the area of space that had been still, where the starlight had paused, started to pulsate and shift once again, breaking the silence.

“Is there only one lantern? Can you tell me more about its surroundings? And where exactly can it be found?” Zhou Ming pressed, his gaze locked onto the Frost Queen’s eyes with intense curiosity, bombarding her with questions.

Ray Nora answered quickly, “There’s just a single lantern, and it’s hanging from a broken piece of wood. That’s all there is—no other objects around. It seems to be suspended in mid-air, enveloped by a dense fog,” she explained. “As for its location, it’s incredibly close to your ‘palace’, almost directly beside it…”

She paused momentarily as if a flood of additional details had just occurred to her. After organizing her thoughts, she resumed, “The lantern itself doesn’t emit a strong light; logically, it shouldn’t be visible from a distance through the fog. Yet, the instant I arrived here, it caught my eye. I maneuvered my ‘drifting house’ closer to it, and it took a considerable amount of time to actually reach it. It’s as if… the lantern’s light isn’t

hindered by the fog or how far away one is; as long as it remains lit in this place, its light seems capable of reaching any location within this fog."

Upon hearing her detailed account, Zhou Ming sank into a deep contemplation. Ray Nora added, "Of course, these are merely my own observations and speculations—you must understand, many phenomena here are… 'unusual', making it challenging for me to discern whether my perceptions or feelings accurately reflect reality."

"I understand," Zhou Ming responded softly. Then, something seemed to jog his memory, prompting him to suddenly stand and walk over to a desk a short distance away.

Ray Nora stayed seated on the sofa, wary of moving. From her perspective, she watched as the mass of previously stationary starlight started to stretch and move in an unpredictable direction, eventually coming to a halt.

Not paying heed to the confused look, Zhou Ming reached for a sheet of paper at the edge of the desk and grabbed a pencil, quickly beginning to sketch. He drew a lantern with a traditional design, crafted from brass, attempting to accurately capture the intricate details of the lantern that hung in the captain's quarters.

After a short time, he returned to Ray Nora with the drawing in hand, showing her the depiction on the paper. "Does the lantern look like this?" he asked.

The entity made of starlight extended its limbs, each ending in numerous eyes that converged their focus on a singular point. In front of these eyes, a holographic projection of a lantern materialized as if summoned from the void.

Ray Nora's body stiffened in response. History had shown that the casual demonstrations of high-dimensional beings could prove fatal to the

unprepared mortal, capable of driving even the most seasoned scholars to the brink of insanity with a mere glance. However, she quickly realized she was not descending into madness.

The multitude of eyes fixed upon her with a softness, displaying a patient and friendly anticipation for her reaction. It appeared she had become thoroughly acclimated to the presence of these starlit beings.

"…It's very similar," Ray Nora found her voice, scrutinizing the projected image with a careful eye. "The details elude me, but the resemblance is striking—somewhere between seventy to eighty percent accurate."

Zhou Ming exhaled a sigh of relief upon hearing her assessment, his theory now gaining substantial credence.

The lantern was "his"—a beacon left by Duncan Abnomar during his final journey in the year 1800, a "marker" akin to a guiding light in this otherworldly domain.

Zhou Ming's mind was awash with contemplation, silence enveloping him as he pieced together fragmented thoughts. The lantern amidst the fog took on a symbolic meaning beyond mere illumination; it served as a beacon of guidance.

For vessels adrift in the fog, a light piercing the gloom signifies the path to safety—a beacon towards refuge.

His own abode, shrouded in the fog, might mark the boundary of this realm or perhaps lay even beyond. Here, the passage back to the realm of order is veiled by chaos…

The presence of the lantern established a "connection"—geographically pointing towards the Boundless Sea and temporally marking the moment when the Vanished would reemerge into reality, signaling the impending conclusion of the Boundless Sea's existence.

Lost in his thoughts, Zhou Ming's gaze drifted, reflecting on the profound implications.

His experiences had led him to a vague understanding of the "deep rules" governing the world, among which the critical role of "information" in the fabric of reality stood paramount.

Evidently, the "captain" who had ventured to the world's edge had also encountered these truths—it appeared that in the final voyage of the Vanished, "he" had come to know many secrets.

Zhou Ming's attention shifted towards the apartment door. Under his intense stare, the door seemed to swing open, revealing the swirling, pitch-black fog beyond—on the other side lay the Vanished, specifically the captain's quarters adjacent to the "Door of the Lost."

That was the lantern's rightful place.

Thus, it was confirmed: the lantern had always been right at his doorstep, a constant presence.

Zhou Ming's focus returned from the vivid imagination of his contemplations, the door in front of him remained closed, a silent guardian awaiting its owner's return to reality from the depths of thought.

Ray Nora, in the meantime, was careful to keep her silence. While she couldn't discern any human-like expressions from the swirling mass of starlight that represented the being in front of her, she sensed its deep engagement in thought. The thoughts of this entity sent ripples through the surrounding chaos, accompanied by a constant, low, indistinct moan that seemed to fill the space around them. She remembered the rigorous training from her youth, designed to keep her from listening, thinking, or trying to comprehend these sounds that sought to invade her mind.

Her goal was clear: to prevent her own thoughts from dissolving into the entity's, to avoid becoming just another transient idea within its vast contemplation.

Thankfully, this intense period of reflection seemed to come to an end—the omnipresent low moan slowly subsided, and the entity's attention returned to her with a gentle focus.

"Sorry, I got a bit distracted," Zhou Ming offered courteously, "Now, let's shift our conversation to your other experiences. I'm quite intrigued."

Ray Nora let out a sigh of relief, grateful for the shift in focus. She found it far easier to talk about her experiences than to "listen" to the entity's thoughts.

"After I broke free, I had trouble controlling my 'drifting house' at first, so I ended up wandering for what seemed like an extended period. In fact, I believe I experienced a longer duration than you might expect, encountering numerous strange phenomena related to timelines along the way…"

Zhou Ming listened without interruption to Ray Nora's recounting of her adventures post-escape. His attention was unwavering and filled with interest as she described the remarkable and supernatural things she witnessed upon gaining her freedom.

For the most part, the tales of her travels didn't offer much in terms of solving the current puzzles Zhou Ming was pondering over; they were largely accounts of peculiar landscapes and phenomena one might encounter in the realm of spirits. However, for Ray Nora, these experiences were beyond anything she could have imagined or encountered during her rule as the Frost Queen.

She had achieved her desire to explore, witnessing a myriad of vistas throughout her extensive journey.

Eventually, Ray Nora came to the topic of the last “disturbance” she faced and how she arrived in this fog-enshrouded location.

“…The disturbance occurred after I escaped subspace while I was navigating just above the abyssal deep sea, under that ‘dome’ with the stagnant starry sky,” she reminisced, “Suddenly, a shockwave erupted from the depths of the sea, seemingly aiming right at me, and forcefully ejected me outwards. Following that was a lengthy period where I lost complete control over my ‘drifting house.’ By the time I managed to stabilize, I found myself here.”

Zhou Ming was deep in thought, his brow furrowing as he pondered the situation. “Could it be the Nether Lord?” he murmured to himself in a low tone, his voice tinged with uncertainty. “But that doesn’t seem quite right… There has to be a reason behind this.”

“The Nether Lord?” Ray Nora, catching his muttered speculation, reacted with visible surprise. “Do you mean to say that the Nether Lord was responsible for creating that shockwave and intentionally sent me here?”

“Just speculating,” Zhou Ming clarified with a shake of his head, aware that no definitive answer was at hand. Thus, he quickly steered the conversation away from the topic. “Let’s not dwell on that for now. Let’s talk about this ‘fog’. Are you familiar with what this place actually is?”

Ray Nora took a moment to consider his question, her silence stretching for a long moment before she gave a complex nod.

“In the beginning, I was clueless. But after spending some time enveloped in this dense fog, I began to witness… ‘phantoms.’ Knowledge seemed to flood into my mind out of nowhere,” she spoke softly, a hint of awe in her voice. “This is the end of the world. Here, I’ve glimpsed the shadow of the end of all things.”

“You should consider yourself fortunate for having followed that lantern to my doorstep and stopping outside my place,” Zhou Ming responded gravely. “It’s a good thing you didn’t venture further into this fog. Otherwise, you might have never found your way back.”

At this moment, even the brave Frost Queen felt a shiver run down her spine.

She realized that she had been like a traveler on a raft, powerless against the current, hurtling toward the brink of a waterfall. Just as she was about to be swept over the edge and into the abyss, she was fortuitously stopped by the only “rock” in the rapids.

Though the collision with this “rock” nearly shattered her.

After a brief pause, however, a look of hesitation crossed her face, and she eventually voiced a troubling thought: “Actually… I ventured a bit too deep…”

Zhou Ming, momentarily caught off guard, responded with a puzzled “Hmm?”

“…After I followed the ‘light’ to your ‘palace,’ I attempted to make contact with the large ‘entity’ there, but you didn’t respond at the time. Instead, a shadow surged out from your ‘palace.’ That indescribable force struck my ‘drifting house,’ causing it to lose control once again for a brief moment, and I was pushed deeper into the fog. Thankfully, it wasn’t too severe this time…”

Zhou Ming’s expression turned slightly awkward at her admission.

Chapter 772: Setting Off on the Journey Again

When Ray Nora shared that an unidentified mass had emerged from his glowing cocoon, momentarily causing her drifting house to veer off course, Zhou Ming's face subtly changed. He took a moment to think and then guessed that this mass might be the "miscellaneous items" he had discarded earlier.

His original plan was to use these items as a conduit for initiating contact with an external entity.

However, the method of communication turned out to be rather forceful.

Luckily, Ray Nora seemed to have not faced significant difficulties due to this incident—and she also failed to notice the brief, telling silence of the "Thousand-Faced Bright Star" before her.

Capitalizing on the opportunity, Zhou Ming steered the conversation in a new direction: "So, after the momentary loss of control, what occurred? You mentioned you 'overshot'… Could you elaborate on that?"

Ray Nora, not suspecting anything amiss, knitted her brows in concentration. After a brief pause, she recounted, "When my drifting house momentarily went off course, I found myself in the thickest part of this fog. Eventually, I came to a halt near an unseen… 'border.' Describing this border to you is challenging… It's intangible, invisible to the naked eye, yet the fog abruptly ends at its edge. Beyond this border is a vast emptiness."

She hesitated, sensing that her explanation still lacked precision, her expression one of vexation. Zhou Ming's demeanor grew more serious: "Emptiness?"

"Yes, a true void. Not merely darkness or 'emptiness' as we usually understand it… I'm struggling to convey this accurately. Even in 'places of emptiness,' there's at least some notion of 'place,' but what I encountered defies logical explanation," Ray Nora said, clearly finding it difficult to articulate and remember her experience, "Consider the perception of the world by individuals born blind, those who've never seen light, who lack visual context. It's commonly believed their world is dark, but their 'vision' is actually an extreme 'void'…"

She paused, using her hands to illustrate her point, "They don't perceive 'darkness' because, in a strict sense, 'darkness' is still a part of vision. Having never seen any color or shape, the concept of 'a world of darkness' is too abstract and unfathomable for them. Thus, from their perspective, their 'view' isn't black but 'void,' devoid of color and form, making the visual world utterly non-existent. That's how I felt beyond that border. I felt as though I should 'see' something, yet it was beyond my comprehension and perception to the extent that my mind couldn't even form an 'image.' I recall hearing some sort of sound then and in my memories of it. Still, my mind was blank. I stood at that invisible threshold, fully aware it was a 'border.' A border implies there's 'another side,' but it… simply didn't exist."

Ray Nora gestured with her hand, her expression still clouded by the unsettling and unnerving memory she was recalling.

"There's no 'other side'…" Zhou Ming's brows furrowed in contemplation as he listened to her abstract and difficult-to-grasp explanations, his mind beginning to draw parallels, "Is it like a sheet of paper that doesn't have a 'back side'?"

Ray Nora’s eyes widened in astonishment, then she observed the “stellar entity” before her as it raised its appendages amidst a backdrop of countless eyes and shimmering starlight, a… form started to materialize.

Zhou Ming took a piece of paper, twisted it, and joined the ends together.

A rush of insight flooded Ray Nora’s consciousness, and in that instant, she grasped the concept of a Möbius strip.

The immense “void” she had encountered suddenly made sense to her.

“That’s exactly it!” she exclaimed, snapping out of her reverie, her eyes locked on the structure ensconced in turmoil, illuminated by thousands of eyes, “This is what I experienced! A boundary without an ‘other side,’ a sheet of paper lacking a ‘back side!’ The ultimate limit, the very ‘end!’”

The form then discreetly disappeared.

Zhou Ming let go of the Möbius strip, and as the paper loop settled on the table, he pondered, “Could this represent the outer limit?…”

He was aware that the protective barrier erected by the “gods” was far from simple. The Möbius strip served merely as an easily digestible “analogy”—the two concepts weren’t exactly identical, but based on Ray Nora’s description of the “boundary scene,” there had to be some similarities.

Ray Nora watched him, her gaze filled with confusion and curiosity.

“You’ve ventured to the very edge of the world—maybe even beyond where the ancient monarchs ceased their exploration,” Zhou Ming said to “the Frost Queen,” his voice carrying a hint of unease, “You witnessed… what lies beyond the boundary, yet it was incomprehensible to you…”

A Möbius strip possesses no “end.” For an entity traversing its surface, no matter how far it travels within its continuous loop, it will never encounter the “edge” of the Möbius strip, nor will it be able to discern an “invisible

boundary” there, which can invoke a sense of dread and bewilderment at the “void” perceived. Yet, Ray Nora, in her daring journey, had at some point felt the presence of that “end.”

She had undergone an “ascension of dimensions”. Although unable to “understand” the scene before her and feeling she encountered only “void,” she had, for a brief moment, become someone… standing outside of the loop.

He painstakingly detailed everything to Ray Nora, elucidating the bizarre occurrences she encountered and the true nature of the “dimensional ascent” she underwent over time.

Information surged into Ray Nora’s consciousness, transforming her understanding and very being.

Yet, she embraced these revelations with open arms and sheer delight.

This quest for knowledge was precisely why she embarked on her journey, precisely what she yearned for at this juncture.

She was eager to explore more vistas, to grasp the full meaning of her observations.

“I should leave now,” she abruptly declared, rising to her feet.

Zhou Ming regarded the Frost Queen with a mix of surprise and speechlessness, momentarily unsure of what to say.

“I want to take another look there,” Ray Nora said, turning to him with her gaze ablaze with starlight that seemed to have etched a permanent presence in her eyes, “With my newfound understanding, I feel… this time, I might actually perceive something within that ‘void,’ perhaps… entities that previously eluded my comprehension but truly exist.”

Zhou Ming remained silent for a beat, then slowly got up from the sofa.

“Do you believe that ‘something’ exists within that void?”

“Yes,” Ray Nora replied instantly, her voice carrying a depth of conviction and determination that might baffle others, “I’ve sensed them, heard them, akin to the wind whispering across stones, leaving no imprint on my consciousness as if fingers fail to discern colors or eyes cannot measure warmth. My logic was too limited to grasp the entities beyond that ‘end,’ but now… I sense a shift. I can perceive them, even if only faintly.”

Zhou Ming locked eyes with the Frost Queen. “You’re choosing a path fraught with danger,” he remarked abruptly, “You nearly got swallowed by that ‘end’ before, and yet you choose to return.”

“Yes, it’s a gamble,” Ray Nora responded, her smile radiant and eyes sparkling with an adventurous gleam, “Adventure inherently carries its risks.”

“…Akin to embarking on another ‘Deep Dive Project’?”

“…Exactly, like launching another ‘Deep Dive Project,’” Ray Nora’s smile faded as she solemnly nodded, “My personal Deep Dive Project.”

She averted her gaze, inhaled deeply, and after a brief pause, reflected, “See, I really wasn’t meant to play the role of a ‘queen.’”

Zhou Ming remained silent, his steps carrying him towards the window that linked to the “Drifting House.”

After a moment, he spoke again, “I’m bound to this place—I cannot leave. So, remember to share with me what you discover.”

Ray Nora nodded enthusiastically: “Of course, I’ll be your eyes.”

She then made her way back to the “rift,” poised to return to her drifting house for another expedition, her spirit undiminished by the challenges that lay ahead.

Zhou Ming watched as the determined Frost Queen embarked on her new venture.

For a brief moment, he pondered the propriety of allowing this woman to exit through the window as the commencement of her grand adventure, feeling it lacked the gravitas such a departure deserved.

Yet, he quickly reconsidered… perhaps the informality was fitting.

The queen, once confined, now had the liberty to begin her journey in any manner she preferred.

His visitor had departed.

With a soft hum, the window sealed shut, and the view outside was swiftly swallowed by dense fog—Zhou Ming barely caught a glimpse of the drifting house before it vanished from sight.

He lingered by the window, lost in thought for an extended period, then diverted his attention back inside, his gaze sweeping across the living room.

The recent events felt surreal as if someone perpetually secluded in a cabin had dreamt of receiving a visitor.

Approaching the sofa, however, the sight of the Möbius strip fashioned from a paper strip, resting on the coffee table with its ends still gently curved, grounded the experience in reality.

Beside it, a piece of paper bore the sketch of an old-fashioned lantern.

There had indeed been a visitor.

Zhou Ming exhaled, a sense of relief washing over him, making him feel a tad lighter. He then smiled, shook his head in amusement, and made his way to the apartment’s door.

Upon opening the door, the ever-present, shifting black fog greeted him as usual…

Chapter 773: Leaping Across the Boundary

Duncan gently pushed the door to the captain's cabin open and made his way inside, immediately drawing the gaze of Goathead, who rested atop the navigation table. Under the subdued lighting of the cabin, Goathead's eyes followed him in silence, a stark contrast to the usual bustle of seafaring life.

With a nonchalant air and a wave of his hand, Duncan announced his return, "Duncan Abnomar— I'm back," before peering out the window, curiosity lacing his tone, "Where are we now?"

Before entering the cabin, Duncan observed that their ship had successfully navigated through the ominous dark mist. Now, he noted, the fog blanketing the sea had transformed back to its mundane shade of grayish-white. The dense fog appeared almost serene under the light, rolling silently in the distance.

"We arrived at the boundary line of six nautical miles about fifteen minutes ago. The fleet is currently on standby, awaiting your orders," the Goathead responded, its voice creaking as it moved its head to maintain its gaze on Duncan, "You… seem to have ventured far or been absent for quite some time. At first glance, I scarcely recognized you."

Duncan listened to Goathead's words, which carried a hint of unease, but he merely gestured dismissively with his hand. Rather than approaching the navigation table as he typically would, he pivoted slowly, his attention seemingly caught by something else. His eyes settled on an antique brass

lantern that hung unassumingly on the wall beside him, its presence as ordinary as any other item in the room when unlit.

With a deliberate motion, he removed the lantern from its hook and scrutinized it closely, its antiquity evident in his careful handling.

“Do you intend to visit the lower deck?” inquired Goathead from behind him, a note of perplexity in its voice, “The lower deck is presently calm, requiring no intervention, and given our critical juncture…”

“No, I’m not headed to the lower deck,” Duncan cut in, bringing the lantern back to the navigation table and setting it down with a casual air, “What can you tell me about this lantern?”

Goathead seemed momentarily taken aback by the captain’s abrupt shift in focus, especially after his prolonged absence and sudden return. Nonetheless, it replied after a brief pause, its tone reflective, “In terms of its function, I believe I’ve already informed you. However, if you’re inquiring about its origins… then, I must admit, it was already here when I boarded.”

“This lantern was part of the Vanished from the beginning,” Duncan mused, a spark of realization igniting in his eyes. A question then dawned on him, one he had never thought to ask before, “Wait, how do you know about the lantern’s purpose then? Who explained its function to you? And what about the other items on this ship…”

“The ship itself imparted the knowledge to me,” Goathead began, pausing momentarily as it adopted a more solemn tone, “I am acquainted with the purpose of everything aboard this vessel. A significant portion of this understanding is derived from the ship’s own ‘memory,’ while the remainder comes from…”

It trailed off, allowing its gaze to drift towards Duncan, caught in a brief spell of hesitation.

“From a time long past, when ‘the captain’ was still capable of thought and sporadic communication.”

Duncan acknowledged this revelation with a nod, signaling he did not wish to delve deeper into the matter, and redirected his focus to the lantern in question.

Observing the captain’s intense scrutiny of the lantern, Goathead’s curiosity was piqued. It closely inspected the familiar object and noted Duncan’s grave demeanor, “Is there an issue with this lantern?”

“…It’s fine,” Duncan momentarily hesitated, aware that discussing the subjects related to “the other side” of the door in Goathead’s presence was imprudent. Thus, he opted for a more indirect inquiry, “I was just wondering whether this lantern serves any additional purposes beyond offering solace during inspections of the lower deck?”

“As far as I am aware… its sole function is as you described,” Goathead replied after a brief contemplation, earnestly providing its understanding, “It accompanies the captain through the shadowy recesses, remembered by the ship for this role… perhaps, you could seek insights from Miss Lucretia?”

Duncan considered this for a moment, when abruptly, a shadow began to swell in a nearby mirror, soon giving way to Agatha’s form materializing from within the darkness, “Captain, we’ve intercepted a signal from the direction of the lighthouse, inquiring if an incident has occurred.”

With a sigh, Duncan stood, replacing the lantern on the wall—aware that the Bright Star along with the trio of church warships that served as both escorts and navigators, awaited his directive.

Recognizing the importance of their mission to explore the border, particularly given the perilous nature of the “outer seas” beyond the six

nautical miles boundary line, he knew any delay was inadvisable.

“Instruct Vanna to reach out to her peers. Tell the church warships to draw near the lighthouse and convey to Sailor that he is to be ready at the stern. We’re poised to cross the boundary.”

“Understood, captain.” Agatha gave a respectful bow, her form gradually dissipating into the mirror’s shadow.

Subsequently, Duncan exited the captain’s cabin, his steps taking him across the deck shrouded in fog until he ascended the stairs beside the cabin, leading him to the expansive stern deck.

The Boundless Sea stretched out before him, its surface mirror-like and tranquil under the cover of a dense gray fog. The sky overhead was overcast, yet there was a distinct “glow” permeating the clouds and mist, an illumination unlike that of sunlight or the World’s Creation, casting a diffuse light that saved the sea from total darkness.

This unique “glow” that permeates the border seas is a phenomenon that persists even on days when the sun is hidden from view, casting a surreal light over the waters.

“So many breathtaking scenes, so many mysteries yearning for exploration…”

These words drifted towards Duncan from a nearby presence. Turning towards the source, he observed Morris standing at the edge of the stern deck, his gaze lost in the dense fog stretching into the distance.

The venerable scholar was clad in an old, worn coat, an unlit pipe in hand, his features etched with contemplation. Feeling Duncan’s eyes on him, Morris turned, offering a smile tinged with self-mockery.

“Just a bout of sentimentality, Captain. It’s hard not to feel a twinge of regret when faced with the prospect of the world’s demise and surrounded

by innumerable phenomena that could occupy several lifetimes of study."

Duncan remained silent, simply joining the old scholar to gaze out into the fog.

Amidst the mist, a monumental lighthouse loomed, an architectural marvel that merged the functionality of a lighthouse, the sanctity of a church, and the innovation of a steam-powered platform. At its foundation lay a steam core, powering a vast harbor, atop which sat a church, its design inspired by the storm. The church's central spire served as the base for the lighthouse, around which a solemn black structure twisted upward, forming a spiraling exterior. Sacred steam pipes, nestled between each twist of the spiral, were visible, and crowning the structure was the "torch," a blessed flame that shone with an intensity surpassing any mundane light, its brilliance a testament to the church's prayers. Even in the dense fog that blankets the border seas, its light pierced through the mist.

Yet, its reach faltered at the chaos beyond the six nautical miles, a realm no longer bound by "order."

"That is the 'lighthouse' erected by the Storm Church at the eastern border. The other three major churches control similar beacons," Vanna added, having approached the stern deck as well. "Her Grace Helena mentioned that these lighthouses represent the pinnacle of the churches' achievements in their border expeditions. They can sustain communication and navigation for a short period beyond the six nautical miles boundary line, but that's the extent of their capability."

The sound of steam whistles filled the air, a reminder of the nearby seas' activity. The three church warships, tasked with navigation, slowly passed the Vanished and Bright Star, making their way towards the enigmatic lighthouse shrouded in fog.

The church warships had fulfilled their role; the next phase of “crossing the boundary” was a journey they were not equipped to join. It marked the conclusion of the living’s contribution to the expedition, paving the way for the “ghost ship” to assume command.

Duncan’s attention was drawn by the sound of hesitant steps approaching. Turning towards the source, he observed Anomaly 077 making his way towards him, a figure of uncertainty.

Adorned in a “naval uniform” that he had acquired from an unspecified source, the attire hung awkwardly on his emaciated, decayed form, a stark contrast to the remnants of his original, tattered clothing. The uniform, ill-fitting on his withered body, seemed an attempt to cloak the remnants of mortality.

“This was provided by the church…” Anomaly 077, catching Duncan’s eye, quickly gestured with his hand, “I thought it proper to dress more appropriately… a touch of formality never hurts.”

Duncan offered a nod of acknowledgment and casually inquired, “Are you prepared?”

“…To be honest, I’m feeling somewhat apprehensive,” Sailor admitted, his fingers instinctively adjusting a button on his uniform before he composed himself, striving to project a semblance of reliability, “But I am ready.”

Foregoing further conversation, Duncan lifted his gaze towards the Bright Star and silently communicated: “Lucy.”

“I’m here, Papa.”

“Sailor is set to take control. You’ll need to maintain close proximity to the Vanished,” Duncan instructed with gravity, “Moving forward, I’ll cease to restrain Anomaly 077’s influence and will instead amplify his presence. Should all proceed as planned, the Bright Star will be enveloped by his

powers as well. We'll navigate the 'correct course' towards the final abode of the Storm Goddess."

Lucretia responded with a voice that conveyed both calm and resolution: "Understood, I'll keep pace."

With a nod and a deep inhalation, Duncan's gaze shifted back to Anomaly 077, who had now taken position at the helm.

"…Helmsman, execute your duties."

"Yes, Captain!"

The declaration came with a force and volume that belied Sailor's typically raspy voice. Grasping the helm with both hands, he initiated the transition.

Almost immediately, a greenish light began to shimmer around the Vanished, gradually extending to encompass the Bright Star in its glow.

The sound of squeaking and creaking filled the air as if the very fabric of space was contorting. The visages of both ships took on an ethereal quality before adjusting their bearings and surging forward into the denser fog.

As they embarked on this boundary-crossing venture, Duncan was greeted by the sound of steam whistles.

Initially, it was the trio of church warships bidding farewell, followed by the signal from the border-standing church lighthouse, and finally, the resonant calls from the vessels of the Storm Church anchored near the lighthouse.

These steam whistles, echoing at the edge of the known world, heralded the Vanished and Bright Star as they accelerated once more, bidding adieu to the realm of the living and crossing into the unknown.

Chapter 774: Convergence Window

After they sailed past the critical marker of six nautical miles, the environment around the Vanished and the Bright Star underwent a strange transformation.

The ocean and the fog abruptly disappeared, replaced by an odd twilight that enveloped the sky. This twilight spread everywhere, making it seem as though the entire world beyond the edges of the ships had lost its definition. Every distinct feature merged into a homogenous and indistinct… backdrop. The two ghostly vessels seemed to be gliding through this monochrome expanse as if they were floating in a void.

“…This isn’t what the church’s records suggested,” Vanna remarked, gazing out at the transformed surroundings, her words flowing without thought. “The documents mentioned that even after crossing the six nautical mile threshold for some distance, the sea and the sky should remain visible… I recall Miss Lucretia pointing this out too.”

Duncan, deep in thought, quietly lifted his gaze to observe Sailor, who was now clenching the wheel with a noticeable tension. After a brief pause, he finally broke the silence: “Maybe this is the scenario that unfolds when Anomaly 077 is ‘properly triggered’—we’re navigating through a unique ‘corridor’, shielded from the chaotic temporal disturbances that lie beyond the critical boundary.”

“But how long will we be traveling through this corridor, Captain?” Alice inquired, her curiosity piqued, standing beside him.

After a moment of reflection, Duncan shook his head, indicating uncertainty: “Even I can’t say for sure.”

Alice’s inquisitive eyes then shifted to Sailor managing the helm.

Feeling the weight of her stare, Anomaly 077’s anxiety heightened, causing him to retract slightly and protest, “Don’t look at me, I’m just as clueless. I’m merely handling the ship…”

As he spoke, he endeavored to maintain a stern demeanor, making slight adjustments to the wheel. Yet, in truth, he was unsure of the direction they were headed, merely moving the wheel back and forth to seem occupied. Given the surreal circumstances, the ship’s precise “course” seemed irrelevant to the position of the helm…

Duncan, perceptive but opting not to comment, checked the condition of the Vanished to ensure all was well, then shifted his focus away from Sailor’s predicament. He cast his gaze towards the nearby Bright Star, mentally reaching out: “Lucy, how are things on your side?”

“Everything’s as usual here, apart from Rabbi, who’s so terrified he’s barricaded himself inside a box, refusing to emerge,” came Lucretia’s immediate reply, her concern evident. “He’s incessantly babbling that we’re ‘plummeting’… plummeting towards the ‘end of the world’. It’s quite worrying.”

“Crashing towards the apocalypse?” Duncan’s brow furrowed in concern as he mulled over Rabbi’s frantic declaration. He turned his attention away from the conversation, his gaze sweeping across the deck to the ship’s edge, which was enveloped in a uniform expanse of “gray-white” that seemed to represent a vast emptiness.

“It could be referring to the ‘external barrier’,” Duncan mused, “Or possibly something that lies even further beyond that barrier.”

“Something beyond the barrier?” came Lucretia’s voice, tinged with confusion.

“…Ashes, the chaotic and unfathomable remnants of the old world that weren’t used as ‘building blocks’ for the new sanctuary,” Duncan elaborated, his mind tracing back to a recent discussion with Ray Nora. He remembered the Frost Queen’s words about the extreme purity and the terrifying “void” that exists at the world’s edge. An insight struck him, “… For a fish, the world of air would indeed be an incomprehensible void and an apocalypse.”

On the Bright Star’s bridge, Lucretia, upon hearing her father’s interpretation, seemed to grasp something deeper. She then glanced at the box near the helm, which was gently shaking with Rabbi’s ear peeking out, visibly trembling.

Miss Witch scowled slightly: “…As a creature meant to instill fear in others, must you be so frightened?”

“Rabbi… Rabbi isn’t meant to instill fear, Rabbi is… merely fear itself…” Rabbi’s voice was muffled inside the box as if trying to reassure itself, yet the tone shifted mid-sentence, “It’s truly horrifying, Mistress! We’re plummeting, descending rapidly! Don’t you feel it? It’s becoming colder, darker, more constricted, like plunging headlong into a narrow tube from an endless abyss, about to choke, freeze, be crushed, envision that scenario, imagine it…”

Without showing emotion, Lucretia walked over, flung open the box lid, and hoisted the rabbit up to slam it against the wall with a single hand.

The doll rabbit made a “pia” sound upon impact with the wall, then fell silent.

“So, it’s your imagination that’s vivid, isn’t it?” Lucretia fixed a stern gaze on the flattened rabbit doll as it slowly slid down the wall, and she unconsciously rubbed her arm to ease the chill, “Stop sharing those wild fantasies of yours—keep them to yourself. Otherwise, it won’t just be a matter of being thrown against the wall next time.”

The doll rabbit inflated back to shape with a “poof-bang” sound, shakily stood up, and muttered an obedient “Oh” before heading back towards its box.

However, before it could get far, Lucretia seized its ear, dragging it back towards her.

“Stop idling around, go find a task to occupy yourself,” Miss Witch commanded with a tone that brooked no argument, “Take a handful of your mechanical companions, head to the rear boundary of the ship and stand guard. The essence of the ship’s spirit seems somewhat disturbed in this area… Ensure that none of those devoid-of-soul shadows break free from within. I don’t have the spare capacity to address such nuisances at the moment. Off you go.”

“Oh, alright, Mistress…” Rabbi responded, its head hanging low as it obediently made its way out of the bridge, taking small, dejected steps.

Once the rabbit had departed, Luni approached, her voice tinged with concern: “Wasn’t that a bit harsh on Rabbi? She’s merely frightened.”

“She’s excessively frightened. I needed to find her a distraction,” Lucretia let out a light sigh and dismissed the matter with a wave of her hand, “She originated from the deep depths of the spirit realm, capable of perceiving many ‘shifts’ that are beyond human detection. What seems trivial to me may appear ‘vibrant’ through her eyes…”

She halted mid-sentence, then cast a speculative glance at the clockwork doll before her: “But now that you mention it… didn’t you sense anything? In crafting your mimic soul, I incorporated ‘elements’ from the spirit realm.”

Luni paused, reflecting deeply, then shook her head, “I haven’t sensed anything.”

A hint of complexity shadowed Lucretia’s features as she scrutinized Luni—though perhaps it was her imagination, she couldn’t shake the feeling that ever since Luni began interacting with that animated doll named “Alice” on the Vanished, there was a distinct and pure… “aura” about her. This observation became especially pronounced after the dolls learned the peculiar act of exchanging heads…

Yet, when she last covertly evaluated Luni’s cognitive abilities, no significant alterations were detected—she had yet to bring this up with her father.

“Mistress?” The clockwork doll picked up on the scrutiny, her head tilting in puzzlement.

“…It’s nothing.” Lucretia brushed off the fleeting thoughts, deciding to sideline the odd connections forming in her mind for now. Just then, something in the periphery of her vision caught her attention.

Through the porthole, amidst the vast expanse of “gray-white” that blanketed their view, patterns, and shadows that hadn’t been there before began to emerge, becoming gradually discernible.

“What’s that?” Luni, too, noticed the enigmatic lines and shapes materializing on the “corridor’s outer wall”, her eyes widening in astonishment.

In the instant following her inquiry, the vague, seemingly detached “outlines”, began to shift within the gray-white backdrop.

The once indistinct black lines began to shiver and swiftly reorganize themselves into coherent shapes, while the shadows around them expanded, filling in the outlines with color. A ship, as if being “printed” onto the corridor’s outer wall from the uniform gray-white backdrop, suddenly materialized and started to align itself with the trajectory of the Vanished and the Bright Star.

This occurrence was akin to a wayward traveler abruptly “bursting into” the corridor, and the once abstract and warped shadow of the ship, upon coming into the view of the Vanished and the Bright Star, rapidly assumed a more recognizable… “form”.

Lucretia, caught off-guard, dashed to the porthole with the swiftness of the wind, her gaze fixed intently on the newly appeared ship within the corridor.

She instantly identified the faint emblem emblazoned on the vessel.

“It’s the Sea Song!”

That vessel was the Sea Song, known for its eternal journey, meandering through the shattered currents of time.

It had navigated from a disjointed time stream, finding a brief moment of “convergence,” to intersect with the path of the Vanished and the Bright Star.

The atmosphere on the Vanished’s aft deck turned eerily silent.

Every onlooker was drawn to the vessel hovering “in mid-air” outside, observing its flag becoming more discernible and the name on its hull increasingly visible—the Sea Song was voyaging within its own temporal flow, seemingly oblivious to the nearby Bright Star as if the discrepancy in

time veiled its “vision”. It passed alarmingly close, then approached the Vanished.

There, it adjusted its bearing and emitted a sequence of light signals.

Anomaly 077’s grip on the wheel tightened, his eyes widening as he scrutinized the blinking lights on the Sea Song, silently tallying the sequence and intervals as though he was counting the beats of a long-stilled heart.

“Short light-dark-short light-dark-long light…” He halted his count mid-way, even as the Sea Song continued to flash its signals. Closing his eyes briefly, he then mustered all his strength and shouted with a raspy voice, “Captain! The approaching vessel is signaling their intent!”

Duncan exhaled quietly, his face etched with a blend of gravity and resolve.

“Signal back with lights,” he instructed softly, “Give them our respects.”

Chapter 775: Departed, Far Away

Nina stepped onto the deck, extending her right hand skyward. Suddenly, intense flames erupted from her palm, morphing into a brilliant arc of light capable of cutting through the dense fog. This artificial sunlight danced above the ghostly Vanished, serving as a homage and farewell to those who had perished in a different timeline.

She pondered whether the Sea Song, another vessel entwined in this mysterious event, was aware of what transpired in this alternate moment. Were its crew heading towards their demise or returning from it? In that fleeting instance, as the two timelines brushed against each other and the lights shimmered, did the crew grasp the reality of their doomed fate?

As the moment of temporal overlap faded, the silhouette of the ship began to rapidly lose its clarity, dissolving back into vague lines and shadows, only to plunge once more into the abyss of the “deep sea.”

At the front of the Vanished, a particularly stooped and frail figure stood against the wind, his form quivering slightly. Gripping the ship’s wheel tightly, his gaze remained fixed on the Sea Song. For a brief second, he seemed to want to cry out, but no sound came from his parched, withered throat.

Then, he lifted his hand in a gesture he wished to direct towards the ship he once served and the comrades he once knew—a salute he had reacquainted himself with thanks to Vanna. It was a simple motion, tracing the pattern of rolling waves across his chest, a sign meant to invoke the storm’s protection

and a prayer for safe passage. Yet, abruptly, as if jolted by a shock, his hand retreated to the ship's wheel, gripping it firmly once again.

Around the Vanished, the uniform, gray-white "inner wall" of the ship momentarily roiled with dangerous, chaotic waves, only to quickly settle down as if nothing had happened.

He couldn't afford to let go; he was the one steering the ship.

The brief window of connection closed, and the last glimpse of the Sea Song vanished from sight, marking its final departure from the mortal realm across all conceivable timelines.

Till the very end, Sailor never released his hold on the dark wheel of the Vanished.

Then, approaching footsteps broke the silence. Turning his head with a hint of sluggishness, Sailor saw a tall figure making their way towards him, observing him with a calm demeanor.

Caught off guard, he instinctively straightened up, managing to utter, "Captain…"

Duncan extended his hand, gently pressing against the gaunt shoulder of the ghoul standing at the helm: "Are you okay?"

The ghoul glanced down at his hands, which were still clasping the wheel tightly. His face, a map of wrinkles, trembled slightly as he spoke, "…Look, I'm holding on well. I just loosened my grip for a moment… the ship stayed on course… and then I never let go again… never let go…"

Duncan remained silent, simply offering a reassuring pressure on the ghoul's shoulder once more.

As he started to turn away, ready to leave the helm, the quiet murmur of Anomaly 077 caught his ear. The words were whispered so softly as if

Sailor was conversing with his own doubts: “Will it make any sense?”

Duncan paused, his gaze returning to his helmsman.

“Will all this make any sense?” This time, Sailor looked up directly into Duncan’s eyes, his voice carrying a trace of newfound bravery. His eyes weren’t searching for an answer as much as they were seeking a beacon of hope amidst turmoil, “The Sea Song, the frontier folk, the city-state guardians struggling to keep order, and… us, does any of it make any sense?”

After a brief silence, Duncan nodded calmly: “…Yes.”

Turning back towards the deck, Duncan made to leave the helm area. Just then, he heard Sailor call out from behind, “The first rule of the Vanished’s crew, right?”

Without a word, Duncan simply waved his hand in acknowledgment and continued on his way.

He descended the stairs to the aft deck, which lay in quietude, and whispered in his heart: “Lucy.”

The Sea Witch’s reply was prompt: “Yes, I’m here.”

Duncan took a moment before speaking in a measured tone, “I recall you once told me about a time you inadvertently crossed beyond the six-mile limit into the Eternal Veil’s depths. You got lost, and it was the phantom of the Vanished that guided you back to safer waters.”

There was a long pause from Lucretia before she finally spoke, “Yes, I… always believed it was just a fleeting ghost of the Vanished, emerging briefly from subspace…”

Duncan chose not to respond further. From the way Lucretia spoke, it was clear that the perceptive “witch” had arrived at a realization similar to his

own.

The recent emergence of the “Sea Song” had sharply brought Duncan to an awareness of a truth he had known but never fully contemplated before.

Beyond the six-mile threshold, the fabric of time unravels and reforms unpredictably, where cause and effect weave in and out of coherence. Ships that have completed their journeys may yet traverse these waters anew. It was here, amidst this realm of temporal anomalies, that Lucretia’s vessel once found itself adrift, lost beyond the boundary where linear time ceases to hold sway. In her most desperate hour, it was the ghost of the Vanished, like a beacon through the mists of chaos, that guided her back to the tangible reality of our dimension.

Lucretia had always believed this spectral guide to be the Vanished itself, either slipping through the veils of subspace back into our world or casting a shadowy projection from its enigmatic journey through the realms between.

Yet, a new theory now emerged in Duncan’s mind.

Standing at the deck’s edge, Duncan leaned against the railing, his eyes scanning the monotonous gray-white expanse that stretched beyond the ship’s hull. His gaze seemed intent on penetrating this boundary, eager to glimpse the untamed maelstrom of fog and chaos that lay beyond, where the fabric of existence itself twisted in perpetual tumult.

In that vast, obscured expanse, the Vanished, under the command of Duncan Abnomar, could still be charting its course—perhaps just beginning its voyage, or on the cusp of returning. Maybe it was on the verge of uncovering some profound truth about the nature of their world, or… perhaps it had just lit a lantern at the very edge of existence, illuminating the path to a dormant exile’s refuge.

…

The crisp sound of a match striking shattered the silence within the living room, a small flame inching closer to the wick of an oil lamp set upon the table. The light it cast was gentle, bathing the room in a warmth that, while not as brilliant as electric lighting, felt comforting.

Heidi leaned over to ignite the lamp, casting a glance around the living room before approaching her mother.

The glow from the oil lamp, though modest compared to the brilliance of electric lights, became their primary source of illumination following a directive from the government to ration electricity. This mandate came in the wake of a malfunction affecting several generators in the eastern district of the city, compelling the authorities to prioritize power for essential services like factories, shelters, and containment facilities, thereby relegating residential lighting to more primitive means.

“I wonder when the power will be restored…” Heidi voiced her concern softly, almost to herself.

Her mother responded with her usual calm and steadiness, embodying a tranquility that seemed unshakeable, “That depends on how quickly the generators can be repaired.” She paused, then added, “Did the notice say how severe the damage was to the generators?”

“They didn’t specify the exact damage, but I heard the malfunction isn’t related to machines being bewitched, so it should just be a normal operational issue,” Heidi explained, her tone carrying a hint of optimism. “If past events are anything to go by, it should be fixed in a few days—maybe two or three days if we’re lucky, a week at the most…”

“Gas lamps and oil lamps can still be used, so the situation isn’t that dire, is it?” Her mother offered a comforting smile, then reached for a piece of

paper on the table, extending it towards Heidi. “This is the ‘Message Paper’ that arrived this morning. Could you read it aloud for me? My vision is blurry these days, making it difficult for me to read.”

Heidi accepted the “newspaper” from her mother.

As the night stretched on, engaging in ordinary “reading” activities had become a hazardous endeavor in the city-state. With the majority of libraries and book markets shut down and most newspapers ceasing their nighttime publication, the thirst for information persisted. To satiate this need within the confines of safety, City Hall supervised the creation of the “Message Paper.”

This publication was a streamlined form of a newspaper, crafted with both physical and spiritual safeguards. The paper itself was consecrated and blessed by the cathedral, ensuring its safety from malevolent influences. Its content was meticulously curated to limit the duration and complexity of reading, thus minimizing the risk of knowledge contamination. Additionally, the paper was adorned with sacred prayers and rune embellishments to safeguard the mental well-being of its readers.

Despite these extensive precautions, the distribution of these newspapers was tightly regulated. They were not available for public purchase but were instead delivered directly to individuals who met specific reading qualifications. These recipients were expected to possess a foundational understanding of mysticism and the skills to handle “minor troubles” that might arise.

While the process and regulations surrounding the “Message Paper” might seem burdensome, they were emblematic of the city-state’s commitment to preserving the flow of information within the bounds of modern civilization. Information needed to be disseminated among those qualified to interpret it, then relayed to the broader populace, including those not

directly engaged with the city's governance. Although Heidi was not officially affiliated with City Hall, her interactions with the city's administrators had given her insights into their rationale.

The night's challenges were manifold, yet the city-state endeavored to stave off the "human" decline into darkness for as long as possible, striving to prevent the erosion of civilization itself.

With a sense of duty, Heidi unfolded the paper, steadied her nerves, and began to relay the contents to her mother:

"…The malfunction within the generator has been pinpointed, and the repair teams are working swiftly to address the issue. The engineers on-site have provided an optimistic timeline, estimating that all necessary replacements and repairs will be completed within the next two days…"

"The challenge of distributing food in the northern part of the city has been successfully addressed, ensuring that the city-state's food reserves are now adequately stocked… The lighting infrastructure is fully operational, confirming that the production output of the vertical farms remains unaffected… Additionally, there's good news regarding our mushroom cultivation efforts, which have seen a noticeable increase in yield…"

"In international waters, a tense situation has unfolded in the northern seas. The naval forces of Cold Port and Morpheus Port have converged near a 'sun fragment.' The fleet of the Death Church has stepped in as a mediating force, preventing the situation from escalating further…"

As Heidi read aloud each piece of news, she occasionally paused to offer silent prayers and invocations to Lahem, the deity of wisdom, seeking guidance and protection. However, upon reaching a particular segment of the report, she halted abruptly.

Sensing the shift in Heidi’s demeanor, her mother inquired softly, “Is there any special news?”

There was a brief silence as Heidi absorbed the significance of the final news item on the paper. After a moment of contemplation, she exhaled softly, her voice tinged with a mix of concern and awe.

“…A dispatch from the Storm Church has announced that the border exploration fleet has embarked on another daring ‘cross-border’ mission. The Vanished and the Bright Star have ventured beyond the six-mile threshold…”

The gravity of this revelation lingered in the air, highlighting the courage and audacity of those willing to explore beyond the known boundaries of their world into realms where time and reality itself were fluid and unpredictable.

Chapter 776: Cold Night

Beneath the subdued glow of an oil lamp, Heidi carefully placed a sheet of paper on the table. This paper bore news from a world beyond their small, quiet living room, illuminated only by the lamp’s cozy light and the comforting presence of her mother’s soft, watchful eyes.

Heidi was no stranger to tales of distant adventures. The Vanished, including her father, frequently sent letters home, their words filled with mentions of the borderlands and the grand voyage that lay ahead. She had always known that her father, alongside a renowned captain, was destined for the far reaches of the frontier. Yet, it was only upon receiving official word through the city-state’s networks that the reality of their departure truly sank in for her.

This realization transformed what had been a distant, abstract idea into a palpable truth. As she stared at the concise message, it dawned on her that their journey had truly begun.

Her father, the man she looked up to the most, had set sail into the vast unknown in the cover of night.

“They will be safe,” her mother assured her, pulling Heidi back from her reverie. Her voice was as steady as it had been years ago, during a tempestuous night, as she offered comfort, “You needn’t worry so much, Heidi.”

Heidi turned towards her mother, her expression somewhat vacant: “Is it because of the skilled captain they’re with?”

“No, it’s because of your father—he always makes it back safely,” her mother responded, her smile warm with nostalgia. “He’s taken on many daring endeavors, more than you could imagine. Yet, he always returns to us, eager to share tales of his supernatural ventures… This time will be no different. He’ll come back with stories from worlds beyond ours, and you’ll get to hear an amazing story from him, just like I have.”

Heidi absorbed her mother’s words in silence. After a brief pause, she whispered, “Father, and Vanna… they’re part of something truly monumental, aren’t they?”

“Indeed, embarking on such a journey is always a significant endeavor.”

“What should I do in the meantime?”

“First, you should wrap yourself in a warm coat, then head outside to the community gathering spot. Share this latest update with our neighbors. They’re still awaiting news on the generators and the food supplies,” her mother instructed gently. “Inform those who can’t read, help alleviate their worries, and dispel the fear and tension that’s been spreading. Encourage them not to succumb to despair, to stand strong against the darkness of this prolonged night. Fulfill the promise you made when you graduated from the academy, and then return home safely. I’ll prepare your favorite mushroom vegetable soup.”

Her mother gracefully rose from her seat, setting aside the needlework she had been engrossed in and walked over to Heidi. With a tender touch, she began to smooth out her daughter’s hair, saying softly, “Heidi, these tasks are significant too.”

As her mother’s fingers gently combed through her locks, Heidi paused, caught in a moment of contemplation, before offering a soft nod of agreement. Her eyes lingered on the makeshift “newspaper” spread out on the table, etching its message into her memory once more.

Meanwhile, far off in the northern seas, a unique vision unfolded under the cover of night. A thin, pale golden sheen that could be mistaken for “sunlight” blanketed the ocean, casting a glow over the waters. Amidst this surreal light, a colossal, glowing geometric structure floated on the surface of the Boundless Sea, resembling a crystal mountain. Surrounding it, at the fringe of this illuminated zone, various warships of different sizes patrolled the darkness, their movements reminiscent of a school of fish cautiously encircling their prey.

From the vantage point, Sorenna observed the scene with a somber demeanor. Standing on the bridge, he peered through the expansive windows at the sea stretched out before him, where the artificial sunlight gently spread. At the sea’s horizon, he could just make out the silhouettes of two small speedboats maneuvering ahead of the fleet, their movements deliberate, neither too bold nor too withdrawn, like probing tentacles.

These were the advance guard of the Morpheus navy, cautiously testing the defenses of the Cold Port navy.

Nearby, several warships adorned with black flags sailed close to the zones controlled by the Cold Port and Morpheus navies. Basking in the faux sunlight, these flags bore the barely visible insignia of the “Death Church”. The main cannons of these warships were fully exposed, ready for confrontation.

Sorenna mused that the clergy aboard those church warships must be feeling the weight of the moment, a thought that briefly sparked a twinge of guilt within him.

However, this fleeting guilt was quickly replaced by a steely determination.

Just then, the communications officer received an external radio transmission. After processing the message, the officer looked up at Sorenna, reporting, “Commander, the ‘Mourner’ has reached out. They’re

requesting that we and the Morpheus navy's vanguard each pull back five miles to clear the danger zone."

Without a moment's hesitation, Sorenna responded firmly, "Inform them that the other side should withdraw first. Make it clear once more that Cold Port needs that 'sunlight.' This isn't up for debate—it's an ultimatum, a necessary outcome. The Cold Port navy will maintain its position here until we achieve our objective."

A palpable tension filled the bridge, the atmosphere turning icy as if the cold wind from outside had infiltrated the room, circulating a slow, chilling breeze.

The signalman was ready to relay Sorenna's message to the church warship, which was acting as the intermediary in this tense negotiation. However, before he could transmit the response, a new communication broke through on the radio's open channel.

"…Commander, we've got a message from Morpheus's navy."

Sorenna's expression turned to one of concern. After a brief pause, lasting only a second or two, he approached the communications desk and lifted the receiver to his ear.

The voice that greeted him was familiar, one belonging to a middle-aged man who Sorenna had known for years: "Sorenna, I knew you'd answer personally. Listen, I'm aware of the dire situation in Cold Port, but things are even more critical here in Morpheus. An unknown entity is attempting to make landfall on our coasts. Despite numerous efforts by our defense forces to push them back, they persistently reemerge from the depths… we're in desperate need of sunlight, if only to temporarily halt the 'anomalies' encroaching upon our shores…"

Sorenna replied with a calmness that belied the gravity of his words, “Farview Cliff vanished twelve hours ago, as though cleanly severed from the island.”

An unsettling silence followed his statement.

Sorenna continued, his voice measured yet carrying an underlying chill, “Cold Port is fading into the darkness. Hobo, after all these years, you know what’s at stake here.”

The response from the radio was delayed, filled with tension, until finally, it came through with undeniable urgency: “Your nephew is in Morpheus! He’s part of the coastal defense!”

“…The people of Cold Port will honor his memory.” With that, Sorenna hung up the receiver with a deliberate motion.

In the ensuing cold silence, he turned to face his crew, who awaited his command.

“…Spare the church’s warships,” he instructed, the calm in his voice masking the storm within. “Focus our attack on the ‘Harp.’ Their command center is located there.”

“Understood!”

The bridge crew sprang into action, following Sorenna’s orders, setting in motion the targeted assault. But their efficiency was suddenly shattered by a sharp cry of alarm.

Upon touching the control stick, a sailor found his hand instantly frostbitten, the skin freezing to the metal. In a state of panic, he ripped his hand away, leaving behind skin already turned to ice.

It was only then that the reality of their situation became painfully clear to everyone on the bridge. The cold that had stealthily enveloped them was

now impossible to ignore. Their thoughts slowed as if caught in the grip of the frost, the intense cold biting into their flesh and bones. A mist of ice, thick with crystals, filled the air, swiftly encasing nearly every instrument and control panel in a fine layer of frost.

Reacting swiftly, Sorenna made a dash for his captain's chair, intending to activate the fleet-wide alarm. Yet, he barely managed two steps before being halted by an arm, dry and cold as steel, that obstructed his path.

The bridge was quickly enveloped in a chilling fog, and through this mist, a ghastly figure barred his way. Dressed in the attire of Frost's navy, the figure stood divided, its body gruesomely severed at the waist as though cleaved in two by a cannonball. The figure's head slowly turned towards Sorenna, its skull-like face cracking into a macabre smile as it greeted him, "Good afternoon, sir, please, try to remain calm…"

Frozen in place next to the captain's chair, Sorenna's gaze shifted sideways, witnessing one horrific figure after another materialize from the dense, icy fog, each one seizing control of his crew members. Within moments, the bridge was overrun by these spectral invaders.

Out of the corner of his eye, Sorenna noticed the sea itself seemed to be rebelling, with vast swathes of white fog roiling over its surface.

This icy mist swiftly condensed upon the sea, rapidly freezing the waters and entombing the area in ice. Amidst the shifting, fracturing icebergs, a ghostly fleet emerged as if conjured from the depths – a massive warship accompanied by a flotilla of both large and small vessels materialized, veiled in a shroud of ice crystals. Cascades of freezing seawater poured from their hulls like waterfalls while their deck guns ominously swiveled to target every ship in sight.

The eerie symphony of metal contorting and warping filled Sorenna's ears.

Turning towards the source of the noise, he witnessed the metal wall beside him undergo a bizarre transformation. The steel seemed to liquefy, displaying an unnatural fluidity before the molten segments coalesced into a chilling visage, complete with a single eye masked in frost.

“Sorenna, it’s been a while.”

“Captain Tyrian… or is it Governor now?” Sorenna’s body tensed, his voice low and strained as he kept a wary eye on the Morpheus fleet. “You’re certainly making a dramatic entrance.”

“I usually prefer not to resort to such displays of power against the city-states’ navies – mostly to avoid unnecessary tensions,” the admiral replied, his tone suggesting a rare departure from restraint. “But it seems… today’s atmosphere is already beyond tense.”

Silence fell between them, lasting several seconds. During this pause, Sorenna’s focus remained fixed on the Morpheus fleet.

There, too, was no sign of resistance – a clear indication that the undead had also seized control of their flagship.

Chapter 777: Dissipation and Alliance

The confrontation on the open sea took a turn for the complex when a formidable fleet, shrouded in the chill of mist, made its unexpected appearance, bringing a new dynamic to what was initially a three-sided standoff. Yet, in an odd twist, this escalation seemed to simplify the predicament at hand.

The forces of Cold Port, alongside the Morpheus Navy, found themselves relieved from the immediate threats of crossfire and the daunting presence of the church's fleet.

Sorenna, with a gaze fixed upon the metallic visage before him, displayed a remarkable calmness. His eyes betrayed neither fear nor uncertainty despite being fully aware of the prowess of the "Iron Admiral" commanding the emerging fleet. He understood that while these spectral adversaries could harness the element of surprise to overpower two of the flagships, they lacked the means to dominate the entire fleet. A chaotic battle, should it ensue, promised dire outcomes for all parties involved.

It became evident through Tyrian Abnomar's actions, choosing this mode of encounter, that his intentions leaned towards negotiation.

After a prolonged silence, Sorenna finally spoke in a voice resonating with depth, "Cold Port requires sunlight."

In response, the metallic figure, its speech accompanied by a metallic resonance, added, "Yes, Cold Port seeks sunlight. And now, Hob, your

former ally and the commander of the Morpheus Navy, communicates the same need for Morpheus. But let me tell you, darkness is encroaching upon our world. Jotun City, Haper, Bandor Island, and even distant lands like Feyron and Mok are succumbing to shadows. Only a handful of city-states remain bathed in sunlight… Everyone is in desperate need of it."

Despite the tension evident on Sorenna's face, his reply was even more composed than before, "Captain Tyrian, is there merit in discussing this now? My immediate concern is Cold Port's survival—unless you suggest you'll reveal the 'sun fragment' that plummeted into Frost."

Maintaining its composure, the steel face revealed, "…It's already en route to Cold Port."

This revelation took Sorenna aback, his prepared retorts dissipating into the air, leaving him momentarily speechless.

A hush fell over the entire bridge.

Tyrian's voice then filled the silence, "If you head back now, you should be able to witness its arrival on the northern shores of Cold Port," as the undead sailors, enveloped in the icy fog, subtly withdrew their hold over the crew, positioning themselves aside in a standby manner, "Allow the Morpheus Navy to escort the sun fragment here before this standoff spirals out of control."

Sorenna paused briefly before inquiring, "And of Frost?"

"Frost is under more secure watch than any of you can imagine. We possess our own forms of 'assurance.' There's no need for worry," Tyrian assured calmly, "The paramount task for you and Hob now is to return to your respective city-states and, with the sunlight's aid, swiftly reestablish order."

Breaking the tense silence, Sorenna abruptly inquired, "…What do you want?" His tone carried a mix of suspicion and understanding,

acknowledging the harsh reality that nothing comes without a cost. “There’s no free lunch, I grasp that concept well. Share your intentions, Governor Tyrian.”

The figure, with a face as impassive and cold as steel, locked eyes with Sorenna, revealing, “…I seek to forge an ‘alliance mechanism’ that thrives in the shadow of night,” he declared, his gaze piercing, “orchestrated by Frost, spanning the entirety of the Cold Sea. I demand unwavering support from both Cold Port and Morpheus Harbor.”

Sorenna took a moment to digest the request, quickly piecing together the “Iron Admiral’s” underlying strategy. A crease formed between his brows as he instinctively searched the horizon for the three warships of the Death Church, previously skirting the fringes of “sunlight.” To his surprise, they had already maneuvered closer to the fog-enshrouded fleet, aligning with the fog ship as though seamlessly integrated into their ranks.

“…I understand. Secure the sunlight and shoulder the responsibility. Those averse to bearing it… will fall to our jurisdiction,” Sorenna shifted his gaze from the window back to the metallic figure, giving a nod of acknowledgement, “Regarding Hob…”

“He consented three seconds prior to you,” Tyrian stated, his tone devoid of emotion.

“Very well, I have no further questions.”

With that, the undead receded into the background, and the chilling fog that filled the bridge began to dissipate, leaving behind melting ice crystals. The immense ice floes scattered across the sea’s surface also started to diminish, signaling the lifting of the fog fleet’s menacing presence over the standoff.

A buzzing broke the newfound silence, emanating from the communication station’s handset, accompanied by a blinking light. The communications

officer, hesitantly glancing at his commander, received a stern command from Sorenna: “Answer it. Do I need to instruct you further?”

Upon lifting the handset, the officer briefly paused before looking up, “It’s the public channel from Morpheus…”

Stepping forward, Sorenna took the handset with an air of expectancy, listening intently to the message from the other side.

“Sorenna, listen, upon my return…”

“You’re free to recount today’s events to my nephew—or perhaps, I’ll take it upon myself to do so later.”

“…You truly stand apart from the rest.”

“Yes, thank you, the sentiment is mutual.”

“…Thank you, farewell.”

After hanging up, Sorenna’s gaze wandered beyond the expansive window, surveying the Boundless Sea now engulfed in the cloak of night. The fog fleet gradually receded into the enveloping darkness, becoming a part of it.

As the last traces of pale golden “sunlight” vanished from the sea’s surface nearby, Tyrian inhaled deeply at the ship’s bow, his silence enduring. After a lengthy pause, he slightly turned, posing a question to an unseen companion, “Do you deem this outcome satisfactory?”

The quiet that had enveloped the scene was shattered by a resonant, gravelly voice. Emerging from the gloom, a towering figure adorned in a long black coat, his body swathed in dense bandages, made his presence known. “There is no superior alternative; this is the paramount path,” he declared, his voice echoing a mixture of resolve and somber realization, “The luxury of sunlight is finite, and the erstwhile approach of every city-state scrabbling for survival in isolation has become untenable. A unified

alliance is imperative to maximize the chances of survival for the populace. Rationing sunlight, assembling combined defense fleets, managing resources on a macro scale, and orchestrating a collective defense against the myriad dangers that lurk in the darkness necessitate the formation of a cohesive union. Ideally, this monumental task would have fallen to the church, but their influence, too, has waned."

Tyrian's gaze drifted to the three church warships, their outlines blurred against the night's embrace. After a pause filled with contemplation, he continued, "To transport a fragment of the sun from Frost to Cold Port requires the mightiest of high-speed tugboats for six days—a duration that mirrors the average transit time for sun fragments among the city-states sprinkled across the Cold Sea…"

"In the event of a city-state being suddenly besieged by a catastrophe without 'sunlight,' the delay for aid can exacerbate the crisis to an uncontrollable extent. Hence, the need for several formidable fleets, perpetually patrolling the night, ready to rush to the aid of any city-state at a moment's notice—these fleets, in tandem with the church's own, should safeguard the entirety of the Cold Sea… but solely the Cold Sea."

"Dedicating our efforts to the Cold Sea suffices. Other regions must devise their own strategies," Duncan interjected, his head shaking in dismissal of broader concerns. He then probed, "Yet, amid these preparations, do you harbor no reservations about my directive to dispatch the sun fragment from Frost to Cold Port?"

Tyrian's response was immediate, his head shaking in denial.

Facing Duncan squarely, he elaborated, "Holding the greatest share of sunlight prevents me from establishing a 'Cold Sea Union' that is perceived as equitable and trustworthy. My possession of the sun fragment in Frost undermines any claim to impartiality in its distribution," he articulated

calmly, his lips then curving into a smile, “Moreover… the true safeguard for Frost now lies within your flame, doesn’t it?”

Duncan’s response was a silent yet affirming nod.

Tyrian’s curiosity, however, got the better of him, prompting him to inquire further, “How fares it ‘over there’?”

“We navigate a fissure in time, its duration uncertain,” Duncan replied nonchalantly, his gaze lowering to his own form. To his astonishment, despite bracing for a severance from his “incarnations” upon crossing the boundaries of the six miles mark, it appeared… these avatars of his being remained intact and operational.

Duncan found himself in a unique position, simultaneously engaging in conversation with Tyrian and perceiving the events unfolding in Pland, all while his primary consciousness embarked on an otherworldly journey aboard the Vanished, voyaging to the world’s extremities. This dual experience was nothing short of supernatural.

Noticing Tyrian’s attention shift towards him, Duncan casually mentioned, “This journey, I chose not to bring you along but instead opted for your sister’s company,” his eyelids slightly lifting as he cast a brief glance towards Tyrian, “Do you harbor any resentment towards that decision?”

Tyrian was momentarily caught off guard by the question but quickly regained his composure, his gaze, marked by the presence of a singular eye, returning to its habitual state of calm and severity: “No, I understand my duties. Your decision was made with good reason.”

Duncan detected the slight strain in Tyrian’s tone but chose not to comment, merely allowing a subtle smile to flicker at the corners of his eyes, hidden beneath the bandages.

Together, they turned their gazes towards the horizon.

Time seemed to stand still until Tyrian was startled by Duncan's voice breaking the silence, "Strive to ensure the survival of as many as possible, for as long as possible."

Tyrian looked towards Duncan in astonishment.

Without facing his son, Duncan continued, his voice reflecting on a reflective quality, as though he was imparting a lesson or perhaps reminding himself, "You, Lucy, and everyone aboard the Vanished, every individual within the city-states, each has their own role to play. The overarching mission uniting these efforts is survival—to safeguard everything in this world to the utmost of our abilities: life, memories, and civilization. Strive to preserve, to endure."

His gaze remained fixed on the distance, on what lay beyond the night, as he spoke further, "Even if the dawn ceases to break, even if the night engulfs all, even if the very fabric of reality starts to crumble, and hope seems a distant memory, remember this… persist, if only for one more moment. That is your task. Leave the rest to me. I'll find a way," Duncan concluded, his tone resolute yet tinged with a deep seated determination.

Tyrian, visibly moved and somewhat overwhelmed by his father's words, found himself at a loss for words, sinking into a profound silence.

Duncan offered no more words, simply staring into the abyss of the night, contemplating the journey ahead.

In his alternate perception, the monotonous grey backdrop began subtly shifting, revealing faint light and shadow glimmers. It appeared their traversal through the temporal rift was nearing its conclusion.

Chapter 778: The Palace at the End of the World

Something started to manifest from the indistinct and uniform grey-white backdrop, resembling a long passage finally opening up, with the scene at its exit swiftly coming into view.

With nimble movements, Shirley scaled the mast, her eyes widening in anticipation as she peered into the distance. She couldn't contain her excitement and joyfully called out towards the deck below, "There's something ahead! It's real, not just a mirage. It appears to be some kind of physical object!"

As the end of their "path" grew nearer, the scene became increasingly distinct. The monotonous grey-white surrounding them began to fade away, much like the morning mist vanishing under the warmth of the sun. Duncan was the first among them to notice the shimmering reflection of light on the water as the view became clearer – then, the gentle drift of mist over the water's surface, and beyond that, numerous shapes, both large and small.

These shapes, floating atop the gleaming water, slowly coalesced into a distinct group of islands.

This was the enigmatic "archipelago" that Captain Caraline had referred to in her log!

The entire crew of the Vanished congregated on the deck, their excitement tinged with a slight unease, as they gazed out at the sea and islands that seemed to have appeared out of thin air. They watched as the illuminated

surface of the sea expanded towards them, encircling the Vanished, accompanied by the sudden sound of water crashing against the ship. Then, the ship jerked and vibrated as it entered this new body of water. After their prolonged and mysterious “voyage through the space-time rift,” the sound of waves lapping against the hull was a surprisingly welcome change.

Gripping the ship’s wheel firmly, Sailor stood on the elevated platform at the stern, his gaze fixed on the sea and islands that filled his entire field of vision. Fragmented memories began to surface, a mix of coherent and disjointed images flooding his mind, inducing an ineffable feeling of being out of place in time—

He recalled this location; he remembered the moment the Sea Song finally made landfall on an island after a lengthy drift. He could hear the chaotic sounds on the ship, the crew emerging from a prolonged nightmare akin to the walking dead, the priest who had lost his way suddenly snapping back to reality. He saw people crawling on the deck, kissing the rusted and deteriorating wood, and then transforming into spirits and ashes carried away by the sea breeze…

He recognized this place – it was as though he had never departed, feeling perpetually stationed on the bridge of the Sea Song.

It wasn’t until he felt a slight burning sensation in his hands, still clutching the wheel, that he was jolted out of his reverie.

Looking down, he noticed a thin layer of flame briefly caressing the dark surface of the wheel before it disappeared, along with the stinging feeling.

“I still have a duty… Indeed, there’s an unfulfilled duty beckoning me… I’m grateful for the awakening,” Sailor whispered under his breath, expressing his gratitude to the Vanished for pulling him back from the brink of oblivion. Then, with a renewed sense of purpose, he raised his gaze once more, meticulously steering the vessel amidst the archipelago of familiar

islands, quietly voicing a vow, “Captain Caraline, I’ve made my way back…”

The magnificent exploration vessel, the Vanished, glided cautiously through the mist-enveloped sea, weaving its way among the shadowy outlines of what were called “islands,” its crew vigilant for clear paths through the fog. Trailing closely behind, the Bright Star proceeded with equal caution, its silhouette looming through the mist.

Before long, the deck of the Bright Star became a flurry of activity as myriad white shapes burst into the air. These were numerous paper seabirds, expertly crafted and released into the fog. They soared with purpose, initially encircling the Vanished and the Bright Star in a protective dance before daring to extend their reach, sweeping over the cluster of islands.

Duncan, watching the aerial scouts deployed and guided by Lucretia, noted with a mixture of relief and curiosity that they remained untouched by the fog, uncorrupted and intact. This observation suggested a level of safety in these parts that was unexpectedly reassuring.

“These ‘islands’ are surrounded by numerous slender shadows under the water, resembling sprawling limbs of some great creature,” Lucretia’s voice resonated within Duncan’s mind, her observations adding layers to the mystery, “Moreover, from an aerial perspective, these ‘islands’ share remarkably similar contours, and on closer inspection, one can discern biological structures on their surfaces… They align with the descriptions in the log, revealing themselves to be the carcasses of Leviathans.”

Duncan hummed in response, his attention drawn to the “islands” amidst the fog. In areas where the waters ran shallow, he too could see the elongated shadows stretching beneath the islands – slender in comparison to the islands themselves yet each shadow was vast, dwarfing the Vanished in

size. These shadows lay motionless in the water, indifferent to the presence of newcomers, bearing the unmistakable mark of ancient demise.

Memories of encountering massive tentacles and a hauntingly large eye beneath the ice surfaced in Duncan's mind.

He understood that the "Leviathans" carrying the city-states were no more than replicas fabricated by the Nether Lord. But here, in this remote expanse, lay the true Leviathans.

"Her offspring encircled Her in death, resting at the world's end…"

Morris's voice, tinged with a metallic resonance, unexpectedly joined the conversation. Duncan turned to see Morris had reverted to his "cast form" at some stage, his body a complex interplay of gears and valves, from which occasional sounds of machinery emanated.

Morris, turning towards Duncan, his voice carrying the vibration of springs, remarked, "Conceiving it in thought is one thing, witnessing it with your own eyes is entirely another, wouldn't you agree?"

He paused momentarily, then gestured towards himself, emphasizing a point, "Being cautious is crucial here; after all, flesh and blood are exceptionally vulnerable in these surroundings."

"…At least flesh and blood have the chance of being healed by Vanna, but your brass shell would require a blacksmith – something we're lacking aboard," Duncan pointed out.

"Actually, Nina could assist," Morris responded with ease, suggesting he had considered this before. "I've entrusted her with the blueprints of my design. She's become quite adept."

Duncan mulled over this information, recognizing the logic in Morris's suggestion. Nonetheless, the thought struck him as somewhat peculiar.

At the same time, Vanna found herself at the forefront of the deck, her gaze lost in the distant sea, while an indistinct figure lingered by her side amidst the mist.

“I… can sense Her presence closer than ever before,” she murmured, more to herself than anyone else, “It’s as though the entire ocean is filled with Her whispers… She’s speaking directly into my ear, yet the words elude me.”

“It could be that our proximity muddles the clarity, or perhaps it’s merely senseless babble,” Agatha’s voice emerged from the shadow, her tone serious. “However, you must exercise even greater caution here – as Her saint, your connection and sensitivity to Her influence surpass others, even under the captain’s safeguard. It’s imperative you remain vigilant not to lose touch with your humanity.”

“I understand,” Vanna acknowledged with a slight nod, appreciating the caution.

Agatha remained silent, lost in contemplation amidst the fog. Eventually, she broke the silence, her voice soft, “Have you ever wondered… what the realm of Bartók might look like?”

Vanna, taken aback, found herself at a loss for words.

“The dead Leviathans here form this archipelago, with the storm goddess lying at rest among them. This sparked a curiosity in me about the final resting places of other deities,” Agatha continued thoughtfully, “My faith tells me that souls journey through a gate to find eternal serenity in Bartók’s domain. My experiences affirm that the ‘messengers of death’ exist, navigating the spirit realm, heeding the call of the gatekeeper…”

“But where does this gate stand? Could it be located at the edge of our world as well? Are those messengers present there too? And the souls… the

final wilderness they traverse, does it lie at the heart of a sea like this?”

“The concept feels… difficult to grasp.”

Vanna’s eyes widened, surprised to encounter such queries from a saint and a former gatekeeper. Yet, Agatha’s questions ignited a spark of curiosity within her, compelling her to ponder these mysteries alongside Agatha.

She shifted her gaze, peering into the depths of the distant fog, contemplative and curious.

The “temple” that the “Storm Codex” spoke of, the one that reigns over all storms and serves as the foundational pillar of the sea, what form did it take?

“There’s a significantly large island ahead,” Lucretia’s voice resonated within Duncan’s mind, tinged with a palpable sense of excitement, “And it appears there’s a substantial structure on the island!”

As if responding to their approach, the fog around the Vanished began to withdraw, revealing a clear path ahead. At the end of this newly revealed stretch of sea, bathed in the enigmatic and chaotic light cascading from the skies above, a colossal island came into view for all aboard.

This island didn’t seem to be a mere work of nature; instead, it bore the marks of an architectural marvel, a creation of an ancient civilization. It was constructed from countless enormous black stones, meticulously cut and arranged in complex patterns. These rectangular blocks, both large and small, rose from the sea’s embrace, assembling into an expansive, undulating edifice. Atop this monumental base stood a vast “palace”.

Crafted from stone-like “materials” that shimmered in shades of black and dark green, with crystal-green elements interwoven among the blocks, it boasted a facade that was both somber and intricate. The palace’s architecture was layered, supported by massive pillars at its base, while the

upper sections featured numerous peculiar openings, seemingly designed to accommodate the passage of gigantic creatures.

“Amazing… structure,” Morris murmured, his voice a mixture of awe and disbelief as he beheld the grand palace in the dim light. After a moment’s silence, he managed to voice his wonder, “How was it constructed?!”

“Clearly, this is beyond the capabilities of our current civilization’s technology,” Duncan remarked, his observation casual yet profound. Then, something caught his attention at the periphery of his vision – those… “entities” emanating from the palace’s lower reaches.

They resembled immense limbs or tentacles, akin to those of sea monsters, stretching from the palace’s flank into the watery depths below.

Gomona is there.

“We’re drawing near,” Duncan stated with a sense of gravity, “We’ve located her.”

Chapter 779: Memories Lurking on the Island

As the Vanished and the Bright Star made their way through the scattered, dark “islands” floating amidst the surrounding waters, they slowly neared the central island. This main island, composed of massive black boulders, gave the impression of a gargantuan, man-made structure.

Encircling the vessels, a thin mist meandered through the air like a sentient being, caressing the surface of the sea nearby. The breeze that wafted through this mist seemed to be laden with the soft echoes of whispers and murmurs, blending into a haunting chorus.

Standing at the forefront of the deck, Vanna watched as the island of black rock loomed larger in her view. Without realizing it, her grip on the railing tightened. The sound of the gentle and rhythmic waves began to resonate within her mind, transporting her back to a memory long past. She found herself recalling the very first time she heard the sound of the ocean, which was in the prayer room of a cathedral, standing before a goddess’s statue right after her baptism. It was then that a voice, soft as a sea breeze, whispered to her heart:

“Ah… my little fish… you have come.”

Jerking back to the present, Vanna realized the voice was not a figment of her imagination; it was genuinely echoing in her heart. Almost simultaneously, she noticed the island transform. The imposing structure, resembling a grand palace, appeared to quiver slightly. From every door and

window, countless massive tendrils stretched out, reaching skyward and then plunging into the sea, stirring the waters and intermingling with the mist.

Then, as suddenly as they had appeared, the tentacles vanished, retracting into the structure. However, numerous large and small shadowy figures began to emerge near the island. They seemed to be an assembly of ships from which countless figures disembarked. Like pilgrims, they held torches and flags, stepping onto the black boulders and making their way into the temple through its side doors…

Vanna thought she could hear music, a festive melody of flutes and percussion that played together, creating visions that flickered and faded before her eyes.

She then witnessed crowds embarking on a pilgrimage, the scene shifting to artisans constructing the grand palace. She saw colossal sea creatures and humans alike gathering for a pilgrimage along the vast coastline, observed individuals in elegant attire lighting lamps on elevated platforms, all while the distant horizon slowly succumbed to a crimson hue. She saw eras of war and peace, heroes, travelers, young warriors safeguarding the masses as they reached the temple, only to find eternal rest on the morning of the second day.

Within these visions, Vanna strived to keep her eyes wide open, peering into each phantom scene. She watched as the palace, crafted from black and dark green boulders, opened its grand doors to her. An entity, shifting through countless forms, emerged to greet her, finally taking on the guise of the “Maiden of Tranquility” and proclaiming, “We have been waiting for a long time…”

A sudden, deep vibration emanated from the depths of the ark, rousing Helena from her meditative state.

In the prayer room, the main lights remained off, leaving only the gentle glow of a dim oil lamp burning in front of the statue. Its flickering flame cast moving shadows around the room, creating the illusion of whispering figures lurking within the interplay of light and darkness.

Helena scanned the room, her gaze cutting through the dimness. As the whispering voices faded into silence, she drew closer to the goddess's statue, her attention fixed on a dark red "pillar" that rose from the floor. This was no ordinary pillar, but a nerve cord that stretched from the ark's depths to its current position.

"I think I just heard Its voice," Helena murmured softly.

At that moment, an aged, deliberate voice reached her ears. "They have arrived safely," it said, carrying a tone of satisfaction. "My kin… They're filled with joy, even the Queen is content."

Confusion marred Helena's expression. "Didn't the Sea Song also reach this place before?"

The old voice, tinged with a hint of amusement, replied, "It's different this time, young one. The visitor this time is someone the Queen has awaited for many years."

"Many years?"

"Yes, since the day the 'Sun' first rose…"

Meanwhile, the Vanished had completed a quarter circle around the black island, eventually finding a suitable spot for anchorage through a break in the boulders. Sailor skillfully maneuvered the rudder, guiding the massive ship to a halt near the shore. Subsequently, a smaller boat was lowered, ferrying Duncan and his companions onto the island.

"Let's explore the island; stay put here, don't wander off," Duncan instructed the small boat that had transported them, as it bobbed in a

makeshift “harbor” framed by rectangular black stones.

Following his command, the boat began to sway gently, splashing against the stones.

Suddenly, a wind swept in from the sky, bringing with it a whirlwind filled with countless colorful pieces of paper. This maelstrom, originating from the direction of the Bright Star, landed about ten meters from Duncan, where it took on the form of Lucretia.

With everyone assembled on the island, the firm ground beneath their feet provided a small comfort amidst the foreboding atmosphere of this world’s edge. Duncan stepped onto an elevated rectangular black stone, surveying the pathway that led to the palace.

Vanna began speaking beside the man: “This is a place of pilgrimage. In my vision, I saw numerous people arriving from faraway lands by boat, igniting large bonfires around the island, and adorning the temple’s path with flags…”

Reflecting on her vision, she moved next to another large stone near Duncan, pointing towards a broad, stone-laid path.

“This path leads directly to the temple. In the mornings, pilgrims disembark on the island, forming a procession that stretches from the shoreline all the way to the temple’s entrance. The island itself was constructed by people using a form of technology that’s beyond my comprehension. They melted and shaped stones from the depths of the sea into these massive boulders and then commanded summoned behemoths to erect the island using these hefty stones…”

Duncan absorbed Vanna’s recounting, his imagination painting vivid pictures of how this place must have looked in those bygone eras, now lost to memory. He hopped off the rectangular black stone and led the group

down the ‘Pilgrimage Road’ Vanna had envisioned, heading towards the temple.

“What else did you see?” Shirley inquired, walking alongside Vanna with a look of curiosity.

“Land-dwelling humans lived in harmony with gargantuan sea creatures – they revered these giant sea beings, known as ‘Leviathans’, as gods and divine messengers. However, their reverence wasn’t just religious; it was part of a deeper, more symbiotic relationship,” Vanna explained, trying to piece together the sudden influx of knowledge. “They lived alongside many other titans, of the sky, of the underground, mastering the forces of mountains and glaciers…”

“They forged pacts with these ancient entities and drew strength from the giants, a power so vast it could reshape rivers, lakes, mountains, and the very earth itself, creating wonders beyond imagination… But I struggle to detail these marvels precisely. I’ve only glimpsed fragmented visions and received knowledge from nowhere. I can’t fully envision those scenes; they seem to be ‘Its’ memories. ‘It’ shared these memories with me, then fell silent.”

Abruptly, Vanna’s voice tapered off, her expression clouding with concern as she gazed towards the palace.

“…Its condition is dire; It shared those visions and then ceased to communicate.”

Duncan paused on the side of the path.

His attention was caught by something at the roadside – a withered piece of black material resembling dried seaweed, seemingly inconsequential.

Yet, he furrowed his brow, fixated on the desiccated “seaweed bundle,” sensing something amiss, his face a mask of contemplation.

“What’s that?” Nina noticed and moved closer to the object, tempted to pick it up for a closer look but stopped short, turning to Duncan with a puzzled look, “Did you find something odd?”

Duncan brooded for a moment before bending down towards the withered black material, extending his hand. Then, something remarkable occurred.

The desiccated material began to transform, causing a dizzying visual effect. It elongated, reconfigured, and by the time Duncan made contact, it had morphed into a crude cylindrical shape. As he lifted it, the cylinder’s surface unveiled intricate patterns, along with features resembling buttons and indicator lights.

Duncan examined the complex cylindrical object in his hand with a contemplative gaze before decisively pressing the most prominent button on its surface.

Immediately, vibrant music emanated from the device, a harmonious blend of drums, bells, and flutes filling the air.

He remained silent, his gaze fixed on the cylinder for an extended period. Without uttering a word, Duncan resumed his march forward, the device still in his grasp.

Vanna paused, momentarily taken aback. The memories of the island that had flooded her mind now converged once more in her vision. She envisioned the original owner of this small device—a child, trudging alongside a group of refugees. With hand extended and led by an adult, the child clutched the device as it played a lively tune.

As the vision faded, Vanna realized Duncan had moved significantly ahead. She hurried to close the distance between them.

Upon reaching the somber black temple, a vast circular plaza unfolded before them. A solitary figure stood in silence at the plaza’s center.

Lucretia reacted with swift precision, her short baton at the ready. However, before she could act, the figure in the plaza—seemingly the temple's last sentinel from an era long past—collapsed without a sound into a heap of ashes. These remnants were swiftly carried away by the wind, leaving Lucretia no chance to discern the guardian's appearance, be it male or female.

"…That was the vice-captain of the guard," Vanna abruptly stated.

"The guard?" Morris echoed instinctively.

Vanna's expression was one of confusion as she furrowed her brow, shaking her head after a brief pause. "…I don't know, the thought just came to me out of nowhere…"

Her explanation was cut short by a warping sound.

The melody emanating from the cylindrical device in Duncan's possession began to warp, growing increasingly unpleasant to the ear. Simultaneously, its surface started to lose its color, rapidly withering and distorting until the music ceased altogether within a mere few seconds. The device reverted to a cluster of withered black material, akin to dried seaweed.

Chapter 780: Remains

Crossing the expansive “Pilgrim’s Road,” Duncan made his way to the majestic entrance of the temple – an immense opening that seemed designed for beings of giant stature, narrowing from its base to its peak. The entry was marked by an enormous doorway, guarded by two vast doors made from a material now unrecognizable, showing signs of significant wear and neglect. One of these doors had collapsed to the ground, while its counterpart leaned precariously against the temple wall.

From within the doorway, the soft sound of waves could be discerned, blending with a series of deep, disorderly noises. These sounds suggested the presence of a colossal creature caught in a struggle between sleep and consciousness, its breathing and murmuring echoing in the shadowy expanse. A slight, fishy scent of the sea wafted over from the end of the Pilgrim’s Road, bringing with it a noticeable coolness.

Morris, marveling at the sight before him, approached the temple’s exterior wall. He adjusted his eye socket, which retracted to make way for a series of lenses that slid out along a copper track, allowing him to meticulously examine the ancient, weathered dark green stones. “Such flawless craftsmanship,” he observed, “as if these stones weren’t assembled but rather ‘grown’ into this formation…”

Vanna, reaching out to touch the temple walls, shared her sense of familiarity. “I’ve encountered such structures in dreams,” she said, “and during moments of deep prayer… It’s not uncommon for saints to have

visions of towering walls or vast stones stacked high… It seems these visions were alluding to this place…”

Standing before the vast doorway, Lucretia casually tossed a piece of white paper into the shadowy corridor beyond. As soon as the paper left her fingers, it burst into flames, transforming into a figure of fire that resembled a human shape, flying briefly into the darkness before fading.

“Inside… there’s a deep stillness,” remarked Miss Witch with a note of hesitation, “but my magic seems to weaken swiftly as if it’s being suppressed by some unseen force.”

Turning his gaze from the dark interior of the temple back to his companions, Duncan pondered for a moment before raising his hand in a subtle gesture. Suddenly, a pale green flame sparked into existence from nowhere, gently enveloping each member of the group.

Nina initially reacted with a jump but quickly became fascinated, playfully shaping the flames on her arm into a ball and tossing it back and forth in her hand. Vanna and Morris experimented with the flames, engaging in physical movements; Vanna swung a great sword several times, and Morris’s joints emitted loud cracks, while Lucretia watched with a mixture of intrigue and discomfort. She was not entirely at ease with her father’s tendency to conjure flames on a whim and appeared visibly tense in the moment.

However, it was Anomaly 077 who showed the most acute reaction, almost instantly leaping into the air with a scream. It jumped nearly two meters high, shouting in panic as it landed: “Fire fire fire… The Captain’s ablaze, I’m burning, ah ah ah~!”

Shirley, reacting swiftly, conjured a bone spur from her back and knocked the dessicated corpse to the ground with a blunt force. “Quiet down with the howling,” she scolded, “it’s only a little fire – even Dog wouldn’t make such a fuss… hey, stop your trembling!”

“Dog” responded with a jittery, typewriter-like chatter: “I… I’m not trembling… I’m perfectly calm…”

Turning to address his oddly spirited crew with a blend of resignation and bewilderment, Duncan couldn’t help but compare their reaction to the dignified, solemn, or emotionally charged preparations of explorers in other tales. Facing the brink of world-altering discoveries, those explorers might reflect solemnly, mournfully, or even draw on poignant memories of loved ones. Yet here were his “companions,” treating the edge of disaster with the casual air of a day at the market. With patience, he explained, “We stand on the threshold of lands where ancient deities slumber. Your minds will soon be tested like never before. Thus, I envelop you in flames, not as mere spectacle but as a shield against the temple’s ancient influences.”

Anomaly 077, with a sudden spark of comprehension, exclaimed, “Ah, so it’s akin to preemptively striking the hostage to spare them from worse fates…”

Without missing a beat, Shirley knocked him down again, yet upon reflection, she conceded with a nod, “You know, you might actually have a point.”

“Why hit me then!?” protested the animated corpse as it picked itself up, shooting a glare.

Shirley, unfazed, retorted, “Because it looked like the captain was itching to do that himself,” and then, with a playful glance towards Duncan, added, “Right, Captain?”

Duncan, maintaining a stoic facade, nodded. Yet, as he did, he sensed an inexplicable shift in the atmosphere. Was it his imagination, or did the air itself transform with the application of his protective flames? Since their arrival on the island, a somber, oppressive aura had cloaked them all. But

now, as if dispelled by the light of his flames, the group's inherent liveliness seemed to resurface with renewed vigor.

With a thoughtful frown, Duncan felt a deeper connection to the island's mysteries, then redirected his focus towards the darkened entrance ahead…

Their cautious steps into the temple disturbed a silence that had persisted for eons. The pale green glow of Duncan's flames cast their shadows against the ancient, discolored stone walls and floor, creating a tapestry of elongated, distorted shapes. The vastness of the palace interior, coupled with the intensifying scent of the sea and the ambiguous sounds that filled the air, created an atmosphere of overwhelming depth and mystery.

"Mind the shadows at your feet, and be wary of the deceitful silhouettes cast by our light," Vanna advised, leading the way with a vigilant eye. She cautioned the group against heeding any voices that did not belong to their own, adding, "And…"

Her warning glance fell on Morris, "Do not touch anything here."

"I haven't touched anything," Morris quickly defended, a shade of embarrassment in his tone as he raised his hands in a gesture of innocence, "I was merely observing with close interest."

As Duncan led the group through the expansive temple, his vigilant eyes meticulously surveyed the intricacy of its grand design. The pale green illumination from his flame trailed his gaze, casting light into the shadowy recesses of this ancient structure. It was during this careful observation that Duncan's pace noticeably slowed.

Above them, a vast, vine-like structure, pale and eerie, stretched across the ceiling. It snaked its way along the curvature of the dome, traversing the wall to thread itself through an opening at the top, vanishing into the further mysteries of the edifice.

Shirley, catching the direction of Duncan's attention, instinctively lifted her eyes to follow his gaze. The sight momentarily seized her heart – a reaction shared by both. Her mind reeled twice over, teetering on the edge of insanity. The protective flames that encased her, however, flared up, pulling her psyche back from the abyss. These flames, burning at the periphery of her consciousness, mitigated the profound shock induced by the realization that they were in the presence of a god's remains.

With a sudden clarity, Lucretia whispered, "It's the limbs of a god…" Her eyes, wide with awe, scanned the pale structures they had observed from a distance, now understood to be emanating from this very place.

With a hint of humor in his voice, Dog remarked, "Seeing it up close truly differs from a distant glimpse. I almost believed I felt my heart beat once more."

Duncan issued a casual yet stern warning, "Be cautious not to fixate on these limbs for too long," before urging the group onward.

As they delved further into the depths of the temple, the sights became increasingly surreal.

Enormous tentacles, some as robust as ship masts, others sprawling across the ceiling wide enough to rival the breadth of medium-sized vessels, entwined in a chaotic embrace. These tentacles pervaded every corridor and chamber like an invasive root system, intertwining with the architecture itself. They seemed to both nurture and consume the palace, integrating and outright replacing the original structural elements in some places.

In one particularly striking hall, the amalgamation of tentacles and unidentifiable organic structures nearly occupied the entire space, leaving the explorers in a state of bewildered awe. The mere sight of this biological marvel, devoid of any divine mental influence, was enough to push the fragile-minded to the brink of madness.

Duncan had every reason to believe that this overwhelming display represented merely a fraction of a larger, unseen entity. Much more of this is likely to lie concealed beneath the island or deep within the ocean's abyss.

The temple, he surmised, served as a mere point of contact—a vestibule for terrestrial pilgrims to commune with a vast marine deity. The Leviathan Queen, extending merely a portion of her tentacles from the depths, created this sanctuary to engage with the humans once under her protection.

Their journey through the temple culminated at the threshold of a long corridor, which ended not in another chamber but before a vast, lake-like pool of water, suggesting an indoor sea. This unexpected vista marked a pause in their exploration, hinting at the profound connections and mysteries lying ahead.

They found themselves in a vast circular chamber, where the floor gently sloped downwards to form a depression that cradled a softly glowing, circular pool. This pool, occupying the majority of the room's space, was surrounded by stone pavement. The walls around this chamber were punctuated with numerous doors and windows, through which countless tentacles, vessels, and what appeared to be neural threads wove their way. These appendages entered the room through the openings, plunging into the pool's depths and merging into an intricate, complex structure that was beyond the capacity of human sight to fully discern.

Parts of this massive limb structure had emerged from the water, lying inert on the stone paving. Close to where these parts lay sprawled, there were bits of debris, suggesting some form of decay or destruction.

Overwhelmed by the scale of what they encountered, Shirley finally voiced her disbelief, "Is the building really this big?" She was puzzled, feeling as if

the ‘hall’ they were in was almost as expansive as the entire palace they had seen from the outside.

“Have you noticed that too?” Morris responded, casting a knowing look at Shirley before surveying the surroundings with a contemplative gaze. “The spatial dimensions here… they seem to defy logic. It’s either significantly larger on the inside, or… once we passed through a specific door or corridor, we stepped out of the palace into a connected, secretive space.”

Vanna, meanwhile, stayed quiet, her attention fixed on the lifeless, pale appendages near the water’s edge. Her face was a mask of complexity, tinged with a sense of melancholy.

She was surrounded by whispers, the constant sound of waves in the background, yet she could not make sense of any of it. From the moment she stepped into the palace, the clear, guiding presence of the goddess had faded, leaving her unable to hear Her voice anymore.

Duncan stood close to Vanna, his expression one of intense concentration and doubt.

He had come to this place with the expectation of engaging in a direct dialogue with Gomona, even in her peculiar state of being “dead.” He anticipated that he would be able to hear her voice in some form—be it echoes, visions, spiritual presences, or something entirely different, similar to his encounters with other enigmatic beings in the past. Yet, there was silence.

All that remained was the long-perished remains of what once was, with every trace of essence vanished from the entity.

Chapter 781: A Glimmer of Life in the Hourglass

Frankly speaking, Duncan experienced a fleeting but profoundly disturbing notion for a few brief moments—had he arrived too late?

He pondered whether his slightly delayed departure or an unforeseen hold-up along the journey had caused him to miss a critical moment. The Storm Goddess Gomona, who had seemingly been suspended in a state of death for ten millennia, might not have waited for him to make his entrance and could have fully succumbed to her demise. Was her consciousness now completely extinguished?

However, this outlandish speculation quickly faded from Duncan's mind. He had verified that right up until the Vanished anchored next to this mysterious island, Vanna had been able to "read" the thoughts of the Storm Goddess Gomona. This indicated that, at least until that point, she had remained in some form of active existence.

Could it truly be such a remarkable coincidence?

Duncan cast a thoughtful look towards Vanna, noticing that she, too, was turning to meet his gaze. Their eyes connected for a brief instant before both awkwardly looked away.

After a moment of silence, Duncan softly spoke, "Let's not dwell on it any further. Let's head down and uncover what awaits us," leading the way with the others trailing close behind.

They entered an enormous hall that seemed to defy conventional architectural principles, descending a spiral staircase that felt like navigating through a vortex leading towards a water-filled basin at its base. Nearby lay the immense, pale tentacles of the “Leviathan Queen,” their smaller offshoots intertwining with the dark stone blocks of the structure like roots, withering amidst the steps.

Duncan had the eerie realization that this grand palace, and even the black island supporting it, resembled a colossal, artificial “shell,” within which resided the ancient, divinely touched sea creature. As the creature perished, its body decayed and shrank, leaving behind numerous “chambers”—the corridors, rooms, and halls they were exploring.

They were traversing the interior of the creature’s “shell,” walking over the recesses left by the decaying flesh, drawing closer to the heart of the beast that had ceased to beat.

A greenish glow emanated from the stairs, piercing the surrounding gloom, as Duncan reached the area where the circular pool met the staircase. There, he discovered a slightly raised, arch-shaped stone platform. On it lay a mass of pale tissue, roughly the size of a neighborhood church’s roof, lifelessly sprawled across the platform. And at its side, on the platform’s edge… he observed what appeared to be remnants of tables, altars, and… human skeletons?!

Lucretia was the first to spot the skeletons. She paused, then swiftly moved closer to the stone platform, carefully examining the scene with a gradually deepening frown: “These aren’t the bones of standard humans or elves but bear a structural resemblance… they’re definitely some kind of humanoid.”

Duncan approached the platform, his expression serious as he surveyed the scene before him.

The skeletons were diminutive in size compared to the massive form of the Leviathan Queen, tucked away in a corner of the platform in such a manner that they were initially overlooked upon entering the vast hall.

“Who might have left these here?” Nina inquired, her voice tinged with nervousness and a hint of fear, instinctively seeking refuge behind Duncan. “Could they be explorers who preceded us? Perhaps members of the Sea Song?”

“No,” Lucretia responded, having just remarked, “these bones don’t resemble those of humans or elves—I doubt they belong to the forest folk either, as those individuals possess a distinct, singular sternum.” Breaking the ensuing silence, Anomaly 077 added, “And I recall… the crew of the Sea Song were ultimately enveloped by the mist and foam near the island, finding ‘peace’. It’s improbable they would have left any remains in this temple.”

Without a word, Duncan continued to scrutinize the items scattered amongst the skeletons with a grave demeanor—pieces of armor or clothing, broken weapons and ritualistic objects, and the ruins of a small altar.

Then, Vanna, with a quiet interjection, broke the silence: “These garments… they resemble what I witnessed in my visions, worn by those who once embarked on pilgrimages to this island…”

“A pilgrimage to this island?” Duncan replied, his voice reflecting his surprise, “Before the Great Annihilation?”

The scenes Vanna had glimpsed in her visions were undoubtedly from the era when the Storm Goddess Gomona reigned as “the Leviathan Queen”, predating the Great Annihilation. They hinted at the existence of a civilization that had thrived alongside the Leviathan, akin to the Elves before Atlantis’s downfall or the era preserved in Ta Ruijin’s memories. Could artifacts from such ancient times have endured to the present?

Duncan, marveling at the notion, examined the artifacts surrounding the skeletons. Outside the palace, remnants from the ancient era had transformed into peculiar black, shriveled matter or, as the sailors described, had dissipated into mist and foam in the sea, eluding human comprehension.

Yet, how had these skeletons and their accompanying relics remained intact?

Just then, Alice's voice pierced the contemplative silence: "Captain, look! What's this?"

Prompted by her call, Duncan joined the doll at her location, directing his gaze to where she pointed—a dust-covered object shrouded in tattered cloth near the altar's corner.

It was a delicately crafted, ornate, and ancient hourglass.

After a brief pause, Duncan reached out, lifted the hourglass, and gently blew away the layer of dust covering it.

The intricate symbols and script adorning the hourglass's surface came into sharp relief.

"An hourglass?" Morris observed the object in Duncan's hand with visible surprise, his optical lenses minutely adjusting. Then, sensing something amiss, he remarked, "Odd…"

Intrigued, Vanna instinctively queried, "Odd in what way?"

Morris paused, reflecting on his observations before sharing, "It's stylistically out of sync with the rest of the temple, particularly the inscriptions on the hourglass… While the temple's outer walls are adorned with many runes, the inscriptions on this hourglass clearly belong to a different tradition. It resembles…

As Duncan listened to Morris’s analysis, a realization dawned on him:

Viewed from a side angle, the silhouette of the hourglass, with its two conical shapes pointing towards each other and encased by a decorative framework, bore a striking resemblance to… Bartok’s door.

“…It bears a resemblance to some of the sacred relics associated with the Death Church!” Morris interjected.

The sacred relics of the Death Church… artifacts associated with Bartok, the deity of death?

This revelation made Duncan’s demeanor turn grave. Piecing together the clues—the preserved skeletons and artifacts within the palace—he began to form a theory.

After a moment of deep thought, Duncan turned his gaze back to the motionless remains of the sea creature by the pool. He then gently inverted the hourglass he held in his hand.

The hourglass contained pale golden sand that flowed silently, too faint for the human ear, moving like mist through the “Doors of Death” mirrored in its design.

In an instant, the world seemed to fall silent, as if divided into realms of life and death by some unseen force. Duncan’s surroundings morphed into a monochrome landscape, where every object’s outline shimmered with shifting, ghostly images. In this altered state, all living beings disappeared from sight, leaving only Duncan, clasping the hourglass, surrounded by the skeletons, which began to reassemble and flesh out before his eyes.

The skeletons transformed into living figures—two armored men with stoic expressions and a young woman in white robes who offered him a smile.

Duncan, struck by the miraculous reversal from death to life, was about to speak when the woman in white robes gestured for silence and stepped

back.

At the pool's edge, the giant, pale limb, as vast as a church's rooftop, stirred slightly, its surface starting to shimmer with a luminescent glow. Then, a soft voice echoed in Duncan's mind – "We finally meet, Usurper of Fire."

"Gomona?" With a hint of surprise, Duncan recognized the entity and glanced at the hourglass in his grasp, "…I hadn't anticipated actual results. It was merely a speculative attempt."

"Yes, your speculative attempt was fruitful—within the temple's temporal flow, I was utterly deceased. This hourglass harbors a fleeting essence of life, intended to facilitate our communication under dire circumstances… Upon crafting this hourglass, Bartok had prophesied that you would inevitably turn it."

Hearing the soft voice echo in his mind, Duncan's eyebrows arched in astonishment: "Hold on, are you suggesting… you foresaw my arrival, my act of turning this hourglass, and even this exact conversation? Was everything orchestrated in advance?"

"Indeed, from the moment this sanctuary came into existence, its destiny was sealed. Usurper of Fire… For us, the concept of time does not resemble a river or a linear path; rather, we perceive it as a vast expanse, a tableau fully visible from our vantage point. On this 'Scroll of Time', all conceivable outcomes have reached their conclusion…"

The voice took a brief pause before resuming in a tender tone:

"In this grand scheme, your emergence, Usurper of Fire, marks the sole certainty at the tail end of this Scroll of Time. However, the outcome of this event remains unpredictable."

Duncan, with a thoughtful look, shared his insight, "I've started to grasp the essence of time's flow… What you've described is within the realm of my

understanding, though initially, it’s challenging to reconcile with tangible reality,” he said, surveying his surroundings, “The peculiar flow of time within this temple… That explains why, upon our entry, neither Vanna nor I could detect your presence, and the discovery on the platform…”

His gaze briefly settled on the figures beside him before diverting.

“Seeing those remains led me to suspect a ‘discrepancy’ between the interior and exterior of this temple. Crossing its threshold seems to have ushered us into an isolated ‘branch of possibility’. What’s the reason for this division?”

“To prolong the ‘decay’ of the external barrier,” Gomona explained in a hushed tone, “We are succumbing to decay, Usurper of Fire. It was imperative for us to ‘seal’ our deterioration within, lest the sanctuary’s natural decay prematurely unleashes our corruption upon this world.”

Chapter 782: Residue and Inertia

The fine particles of sand within the hourglass were gently making their way to the bottom, hinting at a passage of time that seemed as if it could go on forever. Duncan held the hourglass with extreme care, engaging in a meaningful conversation with an entity of ancient power.

“The gods are fading away,” was a thought Duncan had come across more than once. The heads of the Four Gods had shared this dark revelation with him, explaining that the decline of the divine was not just an abstract concept but a tangible force. This force was slowly infiltrating the world of mortals, signaling its eventual doom to a catastrophic end known as the Great Annihilation.

Yet, hearing these words directly from a deity themselves painted the crisis in an even more urgent light. It made Duncan realize that the gods had been fighting against this decline with everything they had for as long as they could.

“This sanctuary, which was created in haste, is full of flaws… Everything in it is ephemeral: the protective barrier, the artificial ‘sun’, the fundamental elements that support the islands, and even us. Our end was decided from the start, determined even before the onset of what is known as the first eternal night,” explained the ancient Leviathan Queen. She spoke in a place that lacked color, defined only by shades of black, white, and gray. Despite her powerful nature, her voice carried a surprising gentleness, narrating their collective history to Duncan like a calm dream floating in the depths of the ocean.

“It took a long journey to come to terms with our ‘end’, and an even longer time for Bartok to decipher the enigma of our ‘continuous death’. We represent the ‘inertia’ of a time long past.”

“The inertia of the ancient world?” Duncan mused, his mind racing to piece together his thoughts.

“If you understand the force behind the destruction of our world and many others, then you must also realize that the Great Annihilation didn’t destroy everything in its path. Some ‘fragments’ managed to survive the catastrophic collision of worlds, and we, who are known as ‘gods’, are among these fragments.”

“However, by their nature, fragments are incomplete. Just as dust falling from a boulder eventually becomes sand and loses its original form, we too were irrevocably changed by the force of the Great Annihilation. From that moment, we were transformed into something akin to the glowing ’embers’… Yet, unlike those embers, we were able to maintain our ‘self-awareness’.”

“This consciousness of our past selves gave us the strength to rise from the ashes, trying to shape some of the surviving embers into something resembling our memories.”

“At first, this gave us a flicker of hope, the ambition to rebuild all worlds, to breathe life back into everything that had been reduced to ashes. However, it wasn’t long before we faced the reality of our ‘reconstruction’s’ limitations and began to acknowledge our own waning power…”

We exist in a condition that cannot truly be considered life; we continue as faint whispers of desire encapsulated in lifeless forms. Our ability to remember and be aware of ourselves, along with our memories of the world as it used to be, allows us to function. However, these capacities for ‘recognition’ and ‘remembrance’ are slowly diminishing over time.

“Bartok, who has the most profound understanding of ‘death’ among us, has described this phenomenon as ‘the inertia of the old world’. He argues that our existence continues not because of any decision or strength of our own, but because the ‘world refuses to fade into nonexistence’. The old world, despite being devastated by the Great Annihilation, has left behind a momentum from its existence that survives after the cataclysm, taking shape as the various survivors that outlasted the disaster – in essence, becoming us.”

“The ‘awareness of self’ and the ‘nostalgia for the old world’…” Duncan pondered, holding the hourglass in one hand and thoughtfully stroking his chin with the other, “Are these the critical elements that led to the creation of ‘sanctuaries’?”

“Exactly,” the voice answered, its gentleness masking the seriousness of their discussion, “Using our memories and awareness of self as a foundation, we tried to reconstruct the original ‘keystones’ from the surviving pieces, leading to the creation of numerous pseudo-records related to the Great Annihilation within the world. However, the quest for tangible proof of the Annihilation is in vain, because no such ‘proof’ has ever existed. Even the vast oceans are made up of bits and pieces we managed to recover from the survivors…”

“Yet, the stability of these remnants, as well as our ability to ‘recognize’ and ‘remember’, is constantly weakening over time… This gradual loss is the reason behind the ‘life limit’ concept built into the design of the sanctuary.”

Duncan pondered Gomona’s words, occasionally pausing to reflect and quietly sharing his thoughts, “‘Inertia’ is bound to fade away… which means the Doomsday Survey Team will inevitably face that ‘limit’, no matter how perfectly they carry out their mission, ‘the end of the world’ was predetermined at its beginning…”

He then recalled Crete's admonition: "Continuing with the sanctuary has no point…"

"Truly, continuing with the sanctuary has no point," the Leviathan Queen reiterated softly, providing deeper insight into the statement – "To 'delay' the Great Annihilation any longer is pointless."

A new realization lit up in Duncan's eyes as he looked up, noticing a pale limb beginning to rise from the edge of the pool, with eyes slowly appearing on its surface.

"Do you remember? The cataclysm brought about by the Great Annihilation is not over; it continues relentlessly, attacking the most basic logic of existence. The conflict of principles and the advance of chaos are just its visible symptoms. At its heart, it symbolizes the battle between 'being' and 'non-being' – as long as we, the 'living', continue to be, and as long as the sanctuary exists, the Great Annihilation will go on. It will persist until everything in the world is obliterated, and only then… will the Great Annihilation come to an end."

The pale limb in front of Duncan drooped, its eyes, though non-human, shimmered with an intelligence and emotion akin to that of humans. It was as if, in their gaze, there was a sense of resignation or perhaps deep thought.

"What you see as a rift is actually a 'result', a 'crossroads' where all possible outcomes from every universe come together into one inevitable 'end' – it symbolizes the 'ultimate point' of the vast ocean."

In the silence that followed Gomona's explanation, time seemed to slow down for Duncan. After a moment, he softly said, "So, from the very beginning, this 'world' was haunted by the ghost of its inevitable end."

After a short pause, he looked for Gomona's "eyes" again, piercing the quiet: "Thus, no matter what solution we might find in the end, our first

challenge is to deal with this ‘unending destruction’. We need to find a way to stop the Great Annihilation – but the only way to stop the Great Annihilation is…”

He trailed off, allowing Gomona to finish the thought in her calm voice: “To let the Great Annihilation ‘come to its natural end’.”

A profound silence fell over them, as if the universe itself had stopped to listen.

After a long moment, Duncan exhaled slowly: “This cannot be the ultimate ‘truth’ you wanted to share – there has to be more you haven’t told me yet.”

“Yes, there is more – letting the Great Annihilation ‘run its course’ could take different shapes, but with our current knowledge and abilities, ‘total destruction’ seems like the inevitable outcome of every path. However, as I’ve mentioned, this conclusion is based ‘on our current knowledge and abilities’…”

The pale limb lowered once more, making way for a spectral figure – a girl in a flowing dress, her face hidden behind a veil, who approached the edge of the pool and bowed deeply to Duncan.

Years before, she had perfected this gesture as a means of communicating with her “mortal allies,” reserved for moments of utmost importance.

“Usurper of Fire, your existence transcends our understanding and capabilities. Technically, you’re even beyond the reach of the Great Annihilation – though you are among the primordial beings, having awakened from the original flames, you aren’t just a ‘survivor’.”

“We can’t fully grasp what you are, but Navigator No. 2’s calculations hint that you might be the only ‘whole’ entity among us – possibly, you have the means to protect the remains of the old world when that ‘end’ comes.”

Duncan stayed quiet, his expression more troubled than before, his thoughts clearly burdened.

Then, it dawned on him – those “objects” that had appeared in his room!

The “Maiden of Tranquility” spoke again, her voice echoing in Duncan’s ears: “Understanding and perception, memory and information – these are seen as the foundational pillars upon which the reality of our world is built. Navigator No. 2 shared with me that it comes from a civilization that was on the brink of uncovering the universe’s basic laws, right before the onset of the Great Annihilation. It was at the peak of this civilization’s in-depth and complex explorations that a certain thinker proposed an idea. This idea is the most remarkable piece within Navigator No. 2’s collection of memories – that information is the core of all that exists; everything is essentially a form of information.”

“Information is the essence… everything is a manifestation of information…” Duncan repeated, his voice carrying a tone of deep insight. It was as though an intense, profound ‘roar’ echoed from within him, shedding light on myriad questions. The space around him seemed to vibrate, edged with the transient glow of stars at the edge of his vision before these images gradually disappeared.

He then heard the “Maiden of Tranquility” again, though her voice now sounded far away, muffled as though through a thick veil: “…To this day, Navigator No. 2 ponders over this concept, its originators on the verge of uncovering a pivotal truth, yet they only managed to pose this idea. With what we ‘survivors’ have at our disposal, in the conditions of the sanctuary, Navigator No. 2 has come to accept the possibility that it may never be able to turn this idea into a solid theory or ‘tool.’ However, your presence… has sparked a thought. There might have been a civilization, even more advanced than the one Navigator No. 2 originated from, that had already crossed that threshold.”

Chapter 783: Handover

The deafening cacophony that had once engulfed his senses began to dissipate gradually, clearing the fog from his perception and bringing the world before him into vivid detail. This experience felt akin to how once muffled and indistinct sounds suddenly sharpened and became apparent as if a curtain of fog had been pulled back to reveal the landscape beyond.

In the newfound silence, the voice of Gomona, gentle and comforting like the soft touch of a breeze over a calm lake, pierced the quiet, asking, “Usurper of Fire, what is your view of the world?”

Taking a moment to consider her question, Duncan repeated her words thoughtfully, “The world in my eyes…” His gaze drifted across his surroundings, taking in the sight of Gomona, who stood before him with a serene presence, the massive, lifeless body of the Leviathan Queen lying nearby, and the peaceful pond where a fish momentarily captured his attention with its graceful leap. This brief distraction led him down a path of introspection.

Turning his attention back to Gomona, ” Duncan took a moment before offering his insight. “My view of the world often diverges from that of others around me. The way I perceive things seems to alter them, and this alteration extends outward, influencing how others see them too. Navigator One describes this phenomenon as the power of the observer, but I feel… the truth might be more intricate than that.”

Gomona’s ethereal form seemed to brighten with a smile at his response. “It appears Navigator Two’s evaluation was precise,” she observed. “The

civilization that stands by you—or, to put it more accurately, ‘they’—have already discovered that ‘answer.’”

Pondering her words, Duncan mused, “…If we consider ‘information’ to be the fundamental layer of existence, is it possible to preserve everything within the shelter while also ‘completing’ the Great Annihilation?”

“If ‘information’ indeed constitutes the essence of all that exists, and we have the capability to rebuild the world from this basic level, then theoretically, any scenario is imaginable,” Gomona answered, her voice as soft as ever. “The absolute ‘everything.’ Every possible and impossible scenario, every being that has ever existed or will exist in the universe, those that were eradicated, and those that survived the Great Annihilation… as long as ‘information’ can define them, they can be recreated in any form… even allowing for a rebirth after ‘destruction’…”

Gomona then paused, her expression turning thoughtful as if she had reached the limits of her understanding. After a brief moment, she gently shook her head, conceding, “That concept is beyond my understanding.”

After a short reflection, Duncan admitted, “…Truthfully, it seems beyond my comprehension as well, at least as the person I currently am.”

Gomona’s face took on a thoughtful expression, her spectral features momentarily becoming less distinct, though the depth of her emotions remained as palpable as any human’s. “You’ve previously mentioned that you possess ‘complete order.’ Could you explain what you mean by that in more detail?”

A hush fell over the temple, encouraging a moment of deep introspection. Duncan seized this opportunity to carefully organize his thoughts, sifting through the extensive information at his fingertips. He aimed to explain his current level of self-awareness and the unique “state” that characterized his being. After a thoughtful pause, he broke the silence with a carefully

considered explanation: “Picture a civilization at the pinnacle of order, capturing a 0.002-second snapshot of the universe at the precise instant it recognized the inevitability of the Great Annihilation. In a bid to conserve a pristine sample of their time, untouched by the looming disaster, they ‘sliced’ this moment out of the timeline, encapsulating it… This fragment, this ‘essence,’ now exists within me.”

Duncan elaborated, his explanation becoming more lucid, “From what I understand, this minuscule piece of the universe serves as the vital seed needed to birth a new universe… it’s like a ‘start parameter,’ a fundamental blueprint from which everything else can emerge.”

He paused, wrestling with the complexity of the idea, but Gomona quickly understood and expanded on his point: “A flawless blueprint, embodying ‘self-consistency’ and ‘completeness’!”

A spark of recognition lit up in Duncan’s eyes: “Precisely, that’s exactly it.”

For the first time, Gomona showed a level of excitement Duncan had not seen in her before. “This is exactly what we’ve been looking for—a pure, undamaged blueprint! Neither our allies nor the civilization that backs us have achieved this, which is why our creations were temporary, like waves in the ocean. But with a complete blueprint…”

Time seemed to move faster, its passage marked by the accelerated trickling of sand in an hourglass. This sound gently pulled Gomona back from her excitement, reminding her of the need to preserve her limited “vitality.”

“With this complete blueprint at our disposal, we have a real chance at constructing a tangible world,” she said, trying to remain calm. “Our previous efforts at ‘creation’ were unsuccessful mainly because we lacked a comprehensive understanding of the cosmic order. If ‘information’ is the foundation of existence, then the universal order is the ‘formula’ that allows

all information to integrate flawlessly. We've never been able to grasp this formula, but you… you have it…"

"But merely having the formula is just the start," Duncan added, "As I've said before, I need resources— and a lot of them. Just as a single seed cannot grow into a giant tree without soil, a blueprint by itself cannot create a house without bricks and mortar."

"I believe we do possess the necessary resources," Gomona confidently claimed.

A look of realization dawned on Duncan's face, signaling a shift in his understanding.

Gomona, with a hint of reluctance, suggested, "Would our sacrifice be enough?" Her voice carried a blend of hope and uncertainty as if she doubted whether their collective offering would meet the requirements.

Duncan's face took on a mixture of emotions, his voice reflecting a complex blend of feelings, "Are you seriously considering that?"

"We hold a substantial amount of 'information' from the ancient world. Navigator Two had informed us of this. Its research, initiated by its creators long ago, is still incomplete. Yet, it has made strides towards the edge of understanding," Gomona explained with a tone of solemnity. "Its findings suggest that the 'information' we carry exceeds our capability to wield or control. Its volume surpasses that of the Boundless Sea. Our failure to harness this information means we are wasting a massive store of 'basic information.' A small portion is used in constructing the shelter, but the rest deteriorates with us, unused and diminishing…"

"But your case is different, Usurper of Fire. Your civilization has reached such advanced levels that you might be capable of utilizing this power effectively. You could potentially orchestrate our 'detonation' in a way that

is efficient. Although we are just remnants of the old world, combining all pieces of the ‘external barrier’ could be enough to support the creation process at least once…”

She paused, the hastening flow of the sands in the hourglass marking a moment of urgency.

After a moment of silence, she continued in a gentler voice, “This is something Salmir couldn’t accomplish back then…”

Salmir, known as the Pale Giant King, had the ambitious goal of reconstructing the stars, but his attempt ended in failure as the stars collapsed under prolonged darkness, caught in subspace.

Duncan stayed quiet, his face revealing his reluctance to consider the Leviathan Queen’s “proposal.”

Both emotionally and logically, the idea of “detonating” the Four Gods along with the remnants of other ancient deities as fuel for a “creation blueprint” was daunting. He questioned whether the explosion of information would be sufficient for such a grand plan.

Admitting this felt somewhat crude, yet Duncan couldn’t ignore the thought that the “informational content” these “gods” contained, including Gomona, seemed minor compared to the vastness of a complete universe.

These were “minor gods” after all—a ship’s mainframe, a recorder of planetary histories, a marine leviathan in charge of a section of the ocean, and an ancient deity of death and sacrifice. Their collective knowledge and memories from the old world appeared too limited to draft a comprehensive map of the cosmos.

Despite his doubts, Duncan found himself unable to express his reservations aloud. The Leviathan Queen, positioned gracefully at the edge of the water, looked towards him with eyes full of hope. This being, though considered a

“minor god” in his eyes, firmly believed that her ultimate sacrifice could significantly contribute to the birth of stars in the emerging world.

After a notable period of silence, Duncan gave a subtle nod in acknowledgment.

Internally, he harbored skepticism, considering this plan to be fraught with uncertainty. He thought it wise to consider other options.

“We’re running short on time,” Gomona reflected, then quickly added, “Naturally, a more reliable solution would be preferable. But should time become too pressing, remember…” she let her words linger, imbuing them with significance, “…we will be here, ready for your decision.”

As the flow of sand in the hourglass increased, the reality of their limited time together became unmistakably clear.

“It seems our time to part is imminent,” the ghostly figure of the girl remarked, as the immense, pale limbs in the backdrop slowly reached towards the water’s edge. “Bartok had mentioned that the remaining vitality in the hourglass would suffice for our essential dialogue—it appears our window for conversation is nearing its end.”

Duncan glanced at the hourglass, observing the dwindling amount of sand. He recognized the necessity of conserving “vitality” for that critical moment when he must return to provide Gomona with the final “answer.”

“Before we part, is there anything else you’d like to impart?” Duncan asked.

A brief silence ensued until a woman nearby, dressed in a white robe that evoked the semblance of clerical attire, approached to hand him something.

Duncan’s interest peaked immediately—it was a brass key, distinctly crafted for winding a doll!

“What is this?” His curiosity was piqued.

“This is the ‘route’ to all the nodes of the entire external barrier,” Gomona explained softly, “Navigator Two was adamant that it should be entrusted to you during your visit here. In your hands, it will reveal its true nature, and you will naturally understand how to use it.”

The idea that the object would manifest its true purpose in his possession intrigued Duncan as he cautiously accepted the brass key.

The key felt cool and substantial in his hand. Unlike another key he was familiar with, which featured an “infinity” symbol, this one’s handle was embellished with an intricate design, surrounded by a ring through which an arrow was threaded.

“I trust this will be of significant aid,” Gomona offered, her smile conveying hope.

Taking a moment to securely place the key on his person, Duncan confirmed, “This will undoubtedly be invaluable.”

Gomona’s spectral nod seemed to signify the end of their meeting: “With that, we have addressed all that was necessary.”

Chapter 784: The Key to the Apocalypse

Everything came down to this simple moment.

As the hourglass was carefully turned over, the last few grains of sand began their descent, marking the passage of time much like the moments of life that slip away, never to be regained. Duncan disappeared into the “spiritual rift,” leaving behind the serene and color-muted hall by the water pond. In this quiet place, made up of shades of black, white, and gray, the enormous limbs of the Leviathan Queen rested gently along the shore. Nearby, a young woman dressed in a white robe and two warriors maintained a respectful silence.

It was time once again for a period of rest, though a brief span remained. The dwindling life force from the hourglass was scarce, yet it afforded a precious opportunity for long-separated friends to share a brief exchange.

“Lillian… it feels like an eternity since our last meeting,” came a soft, resonant voice, stirring the still air of the hall. The pale limbs near the pool’s edge quivered ever so slightly, sending ripples of nostalgia through the room.

The woman in the white robe, Lillian, offered a warm smile and took a seat by the edge of the water pond. She leaned back against a tentacle of the Leviathan Queen, finding comfort in its familiar touch. “Yes, Gomona, it has indeed been a long time since our paths last crossed. But remember, Lancelot and I have always remained close by your side.”

“Do the days filled with gentle waves and radiant sunshine still visit your memories?”

“They do. It feels as though it was just yesterday… I also cherish the memory of our first meeting, when you unexpectedly entered my dream. You confessed how weary you had grown of your temple duties and longed for a brief escape. Together with Lancelot, Owen, and later Paltry, who now guards the temple’s entrance, along with others from our circle, we embarked on an adventure. You wished to witness deserts, volcanoes, and snow-covered landscapes, and so we did. Eventually, I escorted you, our adventurous ‘Queen’ who had fled from her responsibilities, back to your temple, and in turn, we were honored as your royal guardians. Those days were filled with such vibrancy and life.”

“…Indeed, those days were vibrant and alive. Despite the passage of time, the memories remain delightful. We even concocted a plan to covertly open a quaint shop at the pilgrimage’s outset, imagining the Leviathan Queen herself offering souvenirs to pilgrims as a whimsical venture…”

“That scheme was solely yours,” interjected one of the towering warriors, breaking the silence for the first time. “Lillian, Owen, and I never consented to it.”

“…Perhaps we should have,” Lillian mused softly, a hint of regret in her voice. “It does seem like it would have been a delightful endeavor…”

The area around the water pond returned to silence, only to be gently pierced once more by the soft, resonant voice: “I don’t want to go to sleep.”

“But sleep you must, Gomona,” Lillian replied, her gaze tender and caring as she caressed Gomona’s tentacle with her hair. “You need to rest here and then awaken in the timeline beyond the temple… The other three ‘Kings’ are eagerly awaiting your message. Their concern grows by the minute.”

Gomona’s expression conveyed a sense of loss, her voice tinged with longing. “But you won’t be there outside the temple… I miss you.”

In an attempt to offer solace, Lillian spoke with a gentle assurance. “We will meet again one day in the distant future. Do you recall the predictions of Navigator Two? It has analyzed the fate of the sanctuary time and again. Despite its forecasts invariably pointing towards the extinction of all, no prediction is absolute. Though seemingly final, every outcome carries a margin of uncertainty—like a spectral variance that lurks after countless zeroes in a decimal place…”

Her voice softened, carrying the weight of impending slumber, as she continued, “Amidst the ‘end’ foretold as the extinction of all, what lies concealed at the edge of time may hold a glimmer of hope. It’s there we shall meet once more… And then, let us venture forth together, and perhaps, open that souvenir shop once again.”

Her words faded, marking the return of silence as those briefly reanimated succumbed to their eternal rest. After a time indeterminable, the stillness of the water pond area was gently broken: “Goodnight, Lillian, goodnight…”

Reality’s colors reclaimed their presence, the monochromatic hall regaining its lifeless hues. Duncan’s vision was restored to the water pond, now emanating a soft blue light amidst the black and dark green stones, the Leviathan Queen’s tentacle once again lifeless by the water’s edge.

Beside the tentacle lay scattered skeletal remains.

Duncan, observing the dwindling sands within the hourglass—now less than a fifth remaining, their faint golden glow a beacon in the dimness—was approached by his companions.

Shirley, leveraging her stature, pushed to the forefront, concern in her voice: “Captain Captain! What happened? You turned into a shadow, just standing

there. It was so freaky…”

After a moment’s pause, Duncan placed the hourglass upon the altar, then looked up, his voice steady: “I saw the Leviathan Queen and we spoke of certain matters.”

Vanna, moving closer, interjected with curiosity: “You spoke with the goddess? What is this place exactly…”

Before she could continue, Duncan gestured for silence and explained, “This ‘temple’ divides the timeline into two segments.”

This revelation prompted a mix of expressions among the group, with Morris adopting a contemplative look, quietly pondering, “The timeline is split into two parts?”

Duncan took a moment to gather his thoughts before sharing the insights he had gleaned, including some conjectures. “If my understanding is correct, the timeline outside this temple pertains to the ‘Deep Sea Era.’ Gomona, as one of the four deities of the Boundless Sea, oversees the ‘external barrier’ surrounding this temple. Here, she exists in a state that is neither fully alive nor dead, answering the prayers of her followers while maintaining the order of the Boundless Sea—that’s the ‘Storm Goddess’ Vanna knows.”

“And within the confines of this temple lies a segment cleaved from the Deep Sea Era—here, the Leviathan Queen Gomona has isolated her own demise and decay, alongside recollections of the cataclysmic event and numerous fragments of knowledge pertaining to the world’s core essence. She has ensnared all these elements within the temple’s timeline, aiming to shield the sanctuary outside from their corrupting influence.”

Duncan paused for a moment, his gaze shifting back to the lifeless tentacle beside the water pond, and the nearby skeletal remains scattered on the ground.

“This is the reason that upon entering the temple, Vanna found herself unable to commune with the Storm Goddess. All that was visible was a form that had succumbed to complete death—because Gomona confined her demise within these walls. In essence, the moment we crossed into this space, we were met with her actual death.”

Lucretia’s attention drifted to the hourglass positioned on the altar, prompting her to ask, “So, this hourglass is…”

“It’s a means of communication left behind for me,” Duncan confirmed with a nod. “It’s a creation of Bartok, the god of death, who fashioned a bridge between the living and the dead. By inverting the hourglass, I was afforded the chance to converse with Gomona, who was momentarily reinvigorated. Although the remnants of life force it harbors are dwindling.”

A hush fell over the water pond area, the gravity of the revelation leaving the group lost in thought. After a brief silence, Morris, his voice imbued with reverence, finally spoke: “…Remarkable… So, did the god of death and the storm goddess collaborate to forge this sanctuary?”

Duncan responded with a gentle shake of his head, indicating there was more to the story: “Not solely them.”

He mulled over the temple’s intricate workings, slowly piecing together the puzzle. The hourglass’s power stemmed from Bartok, the god of death. The strategy of segmenting the timeline to encapsulate “information” hinted at an association with the god of wisdom, while the archived information and “memories” linked to the Great Annihilation represented the Eternal Flame. Positioned at the boundary of the Boundless Sea, beyond the realm of structured existence, the calm waters served as the “foundation” for this barrier—clearly an influence of the storm goddess.

This entire external barrier was a collaborative endeavor by the four deities, establishing the true limits of the world. It was here that the other Kings

were granted the chance to “forge” the world within the sanctuary, time and again.

As Duncan pieced together his understanding of the world, his grasp of its mechanics grew clearer. The realization of how the external barrier functioned enlightened him and seemed to empower him with a newfound ability to interact with the world’s fabric. This enlightenment quickly morphed into practical knowledge—the kind that could be applied to influence the entire Boundless Sea. More specifically… might be harnessed to bring about the Great Annihilation.

This revelation halted Duncan’s train of thought, casting a shadow of gravity over his demeanor.

It dawned on him that he had uncovered the means to dismantle the external barrier and everything it encapsulated—this, he speculated, might have been Gomona’s true message for him.

Alice, picking up on the shift in Duncan’s mood, moved closer, her expression tinged with concern as she clutched at his clothing. “Captain? You look quite troubled…”

Jolted back to reality by Alice’s presence and the genuine worry in her violet eyes, Duncan’s swirling thoughts began to settle. He inhaled deeply, a soothing gesture as he gently stroked Alice’s hair, offering her a semblance of reassurance.

“Don’t worry,” he said, his voice regaining its steadiness, “I’ve just come to a sudden realization…”

His gaze returned to what remained of Gomona, a symbol of a greater truth.

“If my deductions are correct, the other ‘three gods’ have likely made similar sacrifices—They’ve each ‘sealed’ their ‘deaths’ and ‘corruptions’

within this temporal divide in an effort to stave off the world's inevitable decay."

Nina, catching the serious undertone of the conversation, looked from Duncan to the nearby hourglass, then broke the silence: "So, what's our next step? Are we going to seek out the other three gods?"

"…Yes, that's exactly what we're going to do." Duncan affirmed with a subtle nod.

His path forward was now clear. He intended to journey to each critical point along the external barrier—to lay the groundwork for the Great Annihilation.

Chapter 785: News from the North

In the remote and icy waters of the north, whispers tell of a group coming together under the gloom of darkness. This group is the “Northern City-State Alliance,” a coalition born amidst the eerie quiet of the northern seas.

Leading this formidable assembly is a figure shrouded in myth—the “Iron Admiral.” Commanding an army of the undead, he seized control before the escalating tension among the city-states, exacerbated by their prolonged deprivation of sunlight, could erupt into chaos. The first to align with him were the city-states of Cold Port and Morpheus. In the secretive ambiance created by the Sea Mist, these initial members solemnly pledged their allegiance to the alliance through a binding agreement.

In response to their unified efforts, a formidable naval force has now been established. This fleet stands as a guardian over the city-states left in shadow, navigating the perilous and mystifying darkness that the night has become. Meanwhile, a collaborative endeavor between the city-states and the church authorities has led to the formation of the “Sunlight Distribution Committee.” This committee diligently oversees the remnants of sunlight that plunged into the ocean. Their mission is to ensure that these fragments are harnessed to cast light upon the darkest corners of the night at the opportune moment.

Heidi, having absorbed this intriguing news from the paper, shifted her gaze towards her mother, who was seated nearby, illuminated by the flickering light of a candlestick. Despite the restoration of the city’s electrical power,

which had bathed their living room in bright light once more, her mother preferred to maintain a candle lit at all times.

“Now, no single city-state in the north is permitted to keep a sun fragment indefinitely. The ‘Sunlight Distribution Committee’ circulates these fragments among the city-states, ensuring that no area remains engulfed in darkness for too long, which could lead to dangerous mutations,” Heidi recounted the information gleaned from her visit to City Hall, illustrating how the northern city-states have embarked on a remarkable initiative to ‘share daylight.’ This initiative involves large engineering vessels traversing the Cold Sea, each towing a fragment of the sun. These makeshift suns play a crucial role in safeguarding the city-states…

She took a moment to reflect before adding, “This arrangement has also revitalized maritime trade between city-states. Cargo ships now accompany the engineering vessels, ensuring that despite a decrease in operational efficiency, essential logistics and trade links between city-states have been reestablished…”

After a brief pause, Heidi marveled at the ingenuity of their efforts, remarking, “It’s truly astounding… It appears that the ‘Iron Admiral’ isn’t the tyrannical ‘King of the Undead’ that some rumors make him out to be…”

“Remember, rumors often stray far from the truth. Don’t forget, we still have the Vanished tirelessly seeking hope for us at the world’s end,” her mother replied with a gentle smile, continuing her sewing, “Is this what you found out from City Hall?”

“The newspapers didn’t provide all these details,” Heidi responded, gesturing towards the newspaper on the table, “I got this information from someone in the secretary’s office. The intricacies of the Northern City-State

Alliance and the Sunlight Distribution Committee aren't widely publicized, but they're not exactly secret either."

Her mother took a moment to reflect before responding slowly, "Is that so… It appears that we, too, will soon be part of our own City-State Alliance and have a Sunlight Distribution Committee of our own."

Heidi was caught off guard by her mother's insight; the thought had not yet crossed her mind.

"It's a practical strategy for survival. In these times, any method that enables us to endure the night serves as a powerful incentive for city-state leaders to spring into action. If you've come to know of this, it suggests that the initiative has already gained significant traction among the governors," her mother explained with a casual yet reassuring tone, "The northern city-states have established a commendable model… The 'Iron Admiral' has blazed a trail for us, and with the spread of this news, other city-states, regardless of their private reservations, are now compelled to consider adopting this strategy."

"…But what if the city-states that have already secured fragments of the sun refuse to collaborate?" Heidi understood the logic behind her mother's words but remained concerned, "Not everyone might be willing to share so selflessly, after all."

Her mother paused to ponder before posing a seemingly unrelated question, "Did you hear about the church's fleet docking at the military port west of Pland a couple of days ago?"

"Yes, the 'Cyclone' of the Storm Church and the 'Logic' of the Truth Academy, along with their escort fleets, were reported to have made a stopover during their patrol for maritime safety," Heidi confirmed with a nod.

“That’s correct, Heidi,” her mother said, her face lighting up with an affectionate smile, “Now, why do you think the ‘Iron Admiral’ prioritized establishing a united fleet under his command as the initial step towards forming the City-State Alliance?”

At that moment, Heidi experienced a flash of insight. Despite her credentials as a respected psychiatrist and a distinguished scholar of the Truth Academy, she sometimes found herself a step behind in matters outside her field of expertise. But now, she understood the strategic importance.

“Let’s celebrate, Heidi. After enduring such prolonged darkness, it seems we’re on the cusp of witnessing something positive,” her mother suggested with a smile, gracefully rising to head towards the kitchen, “I’ll prepare some of our finest dishes, and you can retrieve one of the bottles of premium wine your father has been saving. He won’t mind if we open just one.”

“Oh… oh,” Heidi murmured automatically, standing up before a sudden recollection halted her, “Ah, but Dad has quit drinking. He gave away his entire collection…”

“In the basement, beside the white shelf, there’s a wooden box that appears to have just a single layer. But if you tug on a wooden block sticking out from its side, you’ll discover a secret compartment,” her mother revealed nonchalantly, “And, behind the storage rack, in the farthest corner of the basement, there’s a chest containing five bottles of wine. Feel free to pick any one of those to bring upstairs.”

Heidi was momentarily lost for words, “…”

As her mother paused at the kitchen doorway, she looked back with a look of triumph, “Did you really think I wouldn’t be aware of it?”

…

Standing at the bow of the Vanished, Morris was suddenly enveloped by an unexpected chill. The sea around them was tranquil, with hardly a whisper of wind, yet he felt as if an icy breeze was piercing through his brass-constructed body right into the oil pump and the compact steam core nestled within.

“What’s wrong?” Duncan, picking up on the subtle disturbances emanating from Morris, queried with a blend of concern and curiosity.

“It’s odd… my body, being what it is, shouldn’t experience cold, and yet, why do I sense a chill deep within?” Morris pondered aloud, pausing in his maintenance of his pipe, “It’s as though something invaluable has vanished into thin air, or as if an item securely stored in a bank vault has been stolen…”

Before he could finish his thought, the captain interjected from behind, his tone light yet pointed: “Your words bring to mind an old man whose treasures were pilfered by monkeys.”

Turning to face the voice, Morris found Duncan observing him, an inscrutable look upon his face.

“I’m unfamiliar with that tale,” Morris admitted, his expression one of genuine confusion, “What, exactly, is a ‘monkey’?”

Duncan paused, seemingly searching for the simplest explanation: “… Imagine it as a creature from another dimension, existing in subspace.”

Morris, struck by the concept, chose not to delve deeper into the mystery. Meanwhile, Vanna, who had been earnestly following their exchange, turned her gaze towards Morris, her demeanor growing increasingly serious: “Could this be an omen from the god of wisdom? Do you have a premonition of impending events?”

“It’s unlikely to be that grave,” Morris quickly dismissed the concern with a gesture, “Were it a divine sign from the Almighty, it wouldn’t manifest merely as a chill. It’s probably just my spouse discovering my secret stash of wine again—nothing to worry about.”

“Oh,” Vanna responded, her interest visibly waning as she redirected her attention to the captain, “Captain, when will we depart from these waters?”

The shift back to matters of the ship prompted a change in Duncan’s demeanor, marking the return to seriousness.

His gaze drifted towards the distant island, crowned by a grand palace and encircled by the shadowy outlines of Leviathan remains, as he slipped his hand into his pocket. The cool touch of metal against his fingertips was the “Second Key,” essential for the operation of certain intricate mechanical dolls.

“We’ll anchor here for half a day. I need time to decipher the ‘route’ provided by Gomona,” he declared with gravity, “Until my return, maintain vigilant observation of any activity, both aboard and in the vicinity of the ship. Pay particular attention to any alterations in the surrounding sea and document any occurrences.”

Morris acknowledged the command with a nod: “Understood, Captain.”

With that, Duncan turned on his heel and departed from the deck, leaving his crew to their thoughts and duties amidst the quiet mystery of the calm sea.

The atmosphere grew momentarily still as Vanna turned away, her gaze lost in the vast expanse of the dark sea islands that lay silently in the distance. She seemed caught in a reverie, her thoughts adrift.

“What’s on your mind?” Morris inquired, standing beside her, breaking the silence.

“Since I was very young, I’ve always dreamed of the sound of the sea—the gentle, rhythmic lapping of waves against the rocks,” Vanna shared in a soft, reflective tone, “After completing my religious studies, I learned to pray, and in those moments of prayer, I could still hear the sounds of those waves… The ‘Storm Codex’ interprets these sounds as the voice of the divine realm.”

She took a pause, letting the weight of her words hang in the air before continuing, her hand gesturing towards the eerily quiet sea: “But listen—there’s no sound of waves here. The sea is eerily calm, as silent as the grave, only disturbed by the noise of our ship cutting through the water.”

In her mind, the soothing cadence of the sea waves lingered as if offering comfort to an unseen sorrow.

“These are Her memories,” Vanna whispered, breaking the silence, “She told me She hasn’t witnessed the tumultuous sea in countless years—almost forgetting the sight of wind-driven waves cresting and falling.”

Morris remained silent, simply packing his unlit pipe, offering a quiet presence beside Vanna.

…

In the captain’s quarters, Alice’s curiosity was piqued by a brass key of distinctive design.

“I’ve got a new key!” she exclaimed, a mix of surprise and delight evident in her voice as she examined the key Duncan had given her, “This one’s different; the last one had a figure-eight lying on its side, and this one? It’s a circle pierced by an arrow. What’s this circle supposed to represent?”

“It likely symbolizes the ‘outer barrier’ encircling the Boundless Sea,” Duncan explained with a casual air, then looked at Alice, his expression a

blend of resignation and fondness, “Don’t you feel the gravity of the situation? Turning this key could lead to unforeseen consequences.”

Alice pondered his words, tilting her head in contemplation. After a moment, she seemed to grasp the seriousness but remained uncertain.

“It seems… yes,” she replied, scratching her head, her voice carrying a hint of doubt, “I feel a bit anxious, but whatever comes our way, you can handle it, can’t you?”

Duncan paused for a moment, then let out a resigned sigh, a smile breaking through his solemn demeanor.

“Yes,” he affirmed, taking the key and offering a reassuring nod to Alice, “Leave it to me.”

Chapter 786: Another Alice Mansion?

Alice and Duncan, having worked together on numerous occasions, had a routine that was almost seamless. With practiced ease, Alice exposed the intricate keyhole embedded in her back and sat patiently on the bed, awaiting the captain to activate her mechanism with the winding key.

In his hands, Duncan held a delicately crafted brass key, its handle forming a loop for ease of use. He moved towards Alice with the intention of winding her up when, unexpectedly, Alice voiced a question that halted him in his tracks: “Captain, I have a question.”

Pausing, Duncan looked at her, slightly taken aback. “A question?”

Alice’s voice carried a mix of curiosity and uncertainty. “You mentioned that this key is connected to the three ‘nodes’ along the outer barrier, and since I am Navigator Three, this means I am also linked to them. This implies that I can navigate us to any destination given a path, even to the world’s most remote corners…”

Her voice trailed off, indicating her struggle to articulate her thoughts fully. Duncan, sensing her hesitation, did not press her for clarity. Instead, he waited with a patient silence that eventually encouraged Alice to gather her thoughts and proceed: “So, are there other ‘paths’ we can take? Or, in the absence of this new key, could I navigate us to new places on my own?”

Now visibly puzzled by the sudden depth of inquiry, Duncan responded, “…Why did you start thinking about this?”

Alice's reply came slowly, reflecting her reflective mood. "I just… suddenly felt curious about my own existence," she confessed. "Up until now, I've been happily performing my daily tasks aboard the ship, surrounded by those who clearly understand their roles and purpose. They possess something I've struggled to understand – a sense of purpose. It appears everyone has one except me…"

She paused, lost in thought, before articulating the question that had been forming in her mind: "Should I have a sense of purpose as well?"

Duncan offered a gentle shake of his head in response. "…There's no definitive should or shouldn't," he reassured her, "but that doesn't mean you shouldn't muse over and seek to understand yourself better. Understanding oneself is a crucial part of personal growth, which is always beneficial."

This sparked a new curiosity in Alice. "Can dolls grow too?" she inquired.

"Absolutely," Duncan affirmed. "Growth is possible for anyone who is open to it. Since joining us on this ship, you've experienced considerable growth—you've acquired knowledge, met new people, visited new places, and seen new sights. Growth is about change, about being different today than you were yesterday. And by that measure, you have indeed grown."

Alice pondered this for a moment before a sudden realization brightened her expression. "Ah, so even forgetting a few words I learned yesterday morning counts as growth?"

Duncan found himself at a loss for words, momentarily speechless.

Alice, noticing the silence, prodded, "Captain? Why aren't you speaking?"

Duncan, attempting to maintain focus on the task at hand, responded with a mixture of resignation and humor. "…Sometimes, my words may not capture the full complexity of what I mean," he explained, carefully

avoiding Alice’s inquisitive gaze as he concentrated on the keyhole, “You need to consider these things more dialectically.”

Alice pondered over Duncan’s words but found herself puzzled; she was unfamiliar with the term “dialectically.” Nevertheless, sensing the captain’s assurance, she accepted his explanation with a cheerful nod, expressing her readiness to proceed. “Okay, then I have no more questions! I’m ready! Wind me up, please!”

Taking a moment to gather himself, Duncan inhaled deeply, steadying his thoughts before carefully positioning the brass key in the keyhole on Alice’s back. As he did so, a click sound resonated in the air, indicating the key had found its place. The key seemed to be magnetically drawn into the lock, and as it slid into position, the intricate patterns surrounding the keyhole began to glow faintly. The winding process commenced automatically, accompanied by a gentle clicking noise that seemed almost soothing in its rhythm.

Suddenly, Duncan experienced a familiar sense of vertigo, an overwhelming rush that seemed to reset his senses. Darkness swiftly enveloped the surroundings, akin to a thick curtain obscuring all in its path. Then, a cool sensation swept over him, giving the impression of passing through an unseen portal. In the midst of this darkness, specks of light and shadow danced and reformed, eventually coalescing into a scene of spacious opulence, though dimly lit and imbued with an eerie aura.

Regaining his bearings, Duncan hastily shook off the lingering dizziness and scanned his new environment. He found himself within the confines of a grand mansion, its living room expansive and adorned with a dark red carpet. A spiral staircase curled upwards to the second floor, while high, Gothic pointed windows and a gloomy chandelier that seemed to sway subtly added to the mansion’s somber ambiance.

However, Duncan quickly realized that this was not the “Alice Mansion” he remembered. The ambiance here was darker, the candlelight providing only a feeble illumination that barely pierced the surrounding darkness. The mansion’s ceiling appeared more deteriorated, with parts revealing a skeleton-like structure, creating an atmosphere even more sinister and foreboding than he recalled. It felt as if unseen entities lurked in the shadows, observing the newcomers with an invisible, chilling gaze.

With a sense of unease, Duncan noted he was standing on a second-floor platform. Overlooking the hall below through the open space at the platform’s edge, he caught sight of the spiral staircase that descended into the hall. After a moment’s deliberation, he decided against descending to the first floor. Instead, he turned and made his way towards the corridor that led deeper into the mansion’s second floor, determined to explore further.

As Duncan shifted direction, a sudden gleam in his peripheral vision halted him in his tracks. The fleeting glow that captured his attention sent a ripple of anticipation through him. Curious, he moved toward the source of the light, pushing aside the encompassing shadows as if they were tangible, thick curtains of darkness. As he dispersed the gloom, what he discovered seemed utterly incongruous with the surroundings.

Before him was what appeared to be a modern “screen,” akin to an LCD panel.

This object was incongruously embedded into the wall at the corridor’s end. Its silver-white metallic frame seemed to fuse seamlessly with the wall, creating a surreal integration, while the screen’s surface emitted a soft glow.

Duncan scrutinized the text on the “screen” for a brief moment, recognizing its similarity to the device he encountered within the illusionary “Holy Island” cave. The text’s meaning unfurled in his mind as clear information — “Core escape pod offline. Illegal release, operation unauthorized.”

He absorbed the message, a wave of realization washing over him as he turned to gaze at the corridor's damaged terminus and the "great void" beyond. His thoughts shifted between the "New Hope navigation segment" and the "Alice Mansion," leading him to a startling conclusion he hadn't reached until now.

The Frost Queen had commandeered the escape pod from the New Hope…

This revelation explained her ability to traverse the world with her "room" – the structure was, in fact, a repurposed spacecraft's escape pod!

Chapter 787: Awakening

Duncan found himself momentarily frozen in the hallway, struck by a revelation that was as bewildering as it was enlightening. He grappled with a mix of emotions, feeling both incredulous at the absurdity of the situation and, at the same time, strangely convinced by its logic. This internal conflict swirled in his thoughts for some time before he managed to push aside the desire to voice his perplexities, choosing instead to concentrate on the peculiar “screen” that was integrated into the wall before him.

As he stood there, lost in thought, his expression slowly shifted to one of deep reflection.

The cataclysm known as The Great Annihilation had ushered in a “collision of worlds,” fundamentally altering the fabric of reality. The New Hope had not been spared, part of it morphing into what was now known as the “Alice Mansion,” suspended in subspace. Within this mansion, after employing a navigation key to access an alternate version, Duncan encountered a “screen” at the corridor’s end which purported to unveil the truth of the mistress’s bedroom…

In essence, the Alice Mansion that was accessed with the navigation key had parts of its structure “restored” or rather “re-materialized” to their original form.

Mulling over these revelations, Duncan raised his gaze towards the far end of the corridor, pondering what had become of the garden and the doll that once lay there in slumber.

He descended from the second floor, retracing the path engraved in his memory down the stairs, through a narrow passageway adjacent to the main hall, past the now silent rooms that once seemed to whisper secrets, making his way toward the garden.

His journey was momentarily interrupted by a peculiar door along the corridor.

Among the numerous identical doors, one stood out, shimmering with a silvery metallic luster, its edges highlighted by soft blue glowing lines, making it look like a piece of advanced machinery set within the mansion's classical decor. Drawn to it, Duncan approached and noticed an "observation window" set above the door.

Peering through this window, he observed a room bathed in cold, blue light, filled with densely arranged cabinet equipment on large racks and brackets, interconnected by pipes that dangled from the ceiling, linking these enigmatic machines.

Duncan attempted to open the door, only to find it immovable, as if it were merely an "illusion" affixed to the wall, never meant to "open."

Yet, as he studied the room's interior, Duncan found himself deep in thought.

He recalled the whispers that seemed to emanate from the mansion's corners in the version of the Alice Mansion he knew well, along with the soft music that appeared to drift from an unseen ballroom within its expansive halls.

…Could it be that those ghostly sounds were in fact the humming of server arrays in operation?

Entertaining this surprising thought, Duncan moved away from the door with its flickering metallic glow, continuing his path toward the garden's

entrance.

The corridor Duncan traversed felt immeasurably longer than he recalled, stretching out before him as if defying the limits of memory and space. Yet, through the dim light, the silhouette of the garden gate was persistently visible, serving as a beacon that seemed to call out to him, urging him to hasten his steps as though guided by an unseen force.

As Duncan advanced, the environment began to reveal startling anomalies. The doors and walls beside him started to unveil their “original” forms beneath their classical exteriors: doors gleamed with a futuristic, metallic sheen; sections of wall transformed into the interiors of spacecraft cabins, complete with embedded lighting; irregularly shaped metal plates surfaced unexpectedly. These remnants of a bygone era emerged amidst the traditionally elegant facades and rooftops like the shedding of dragon scales, revealing the metallic infrastructure and power lines that lay beneath the architectural “skin.”

Eventually, Duncan reached the end of the seemingly infinite corridor, where the garden gate awaited him. Crafted from an array of colorful stained glass and set within a classically designed frame that emitted a soft, pale blue glow, the gate stood in silent invitation. A screen was unexpectedly placed among the stained glass, displaying the words: Navigation Core Server/Mind Core Chamber.

Pausing momentarily in front of this gate, Duncan extended his hand towards it. To his recollection, the gate opened with ease as though it had never been secured, revealing a dimly lit expanse that unfolded before him.

Beyond the gate lay a hall, its farthest reaches shrouded in a mist-like darkness that blurred its edges and dimensions. Within this haze, dark, obelisk-like shapes loomed, their outlines intermittently pierced by

flickering lights. The only clearly visible feature in this enigmatic space was a circular platform at its center.

From above, countless wires and pipes cascaded down, converging on a peculiarly shaped protrusion on the platform. These connections were illuminated by a soft light that danced between them, reminiscent of fireflies in the night. The arrangement gave the impression of a surreal, living “tree,” with light coursing through its “branches” as if it were the lifeblood of the structure.

At the base of this extraordinary and chaotic “tree,” the doll sat silently on the platform’s edge.

She was awake.

Yet, she made no move to acknowledge Duncan’s entrance into the hall. The doll, a mirror image of Alice, sat motionless, clutching a white drawing board to her chest, her gaze fixed ahead in an unfocused stare as if frozen in a perpetual state of readiness.

Duncan inhaled deeply, treading carefully towards the doll at the root of the “tree of cables.”

When he had covered a certain distance, the doll showed the first sign of awareness, subtly turning her head. It appeared as though her attention shifted from the door to Duncan himself.

Despite her slight movement in response to Duncan’s presence, the doll remained silent and expressionless, her gaze following him not with the curiosity or warmth of a living being, but rather with the detached, programmed responsiveness of an inanimate object. She was like a doll in the truest sense, equipped with only the most rudimentary form of interaction: basic motion tracking.

Yet, as Duncan observed this minimal reaction, he felt an unexpected wave of emotion wash over him. This simple, almost ghostly, interaction with the doll stirred a peculiar sense of poignancy within him as if her mechanical behavior had somehow tapped into the eerie essence of their surroundings.

He moved closer to her, and as he did, the doll slowly lifted her head, her eyes mechanically adjusting to keep him in her line of sight, yet without any hint of real recognition or emotion.

Suddenly, breaking the silence, the doll spoke, “There’s no way forward.”

Her voice, unexpected and clear, cut through the room, startling Duncan. He hadn’t anticipated that the doll, which had so far shown no sign of life beyond basic tracking, would speak.

Caught off guard, Duncan responded, “No way forward? What do you mean?”

The doll’s response was cryptic, “Guiding New Hope to jump to a safe domain…”

She turned her head in a stiff, slow motion, her gaze drifting as if she was looking through the fog at the servers hidden beyond, or perhaps at images from a past that had vanished from the space. Her voice, devoid of emotion, reverberated through the hall, “Guiding jump to gravitational focus… Jump engine disabled, star chart malfunction… Standard stellar deviation… No navigation points found, destination analyzing failed… There’s no way forward…”

Suddenly, she seemed to freeze, her eyes widening as though a surge of realization had jolted her from a deep slumber.

“There’s no way forward, Navigator Three apologizes to all crew members, there’s no way forward, apologies, there’s no way forward…”

She began to repeat herself, caught in a tragic loop of apologies, her voice echoing endlessly. A low, ominous noise began to fill the hall, emanating from the fog in every direction. As she continued her distressed repetition, her voice growing increasingly urgent, “There’s no way forward, there’s no way forward there’s no way forward there’s no…”

The background noise escalated into a shrill scream, accompanied by a sensation as if something massive was collapsing within the fog, shaking the entire hall. Just as the situation seemed to spiral out of control, Duncan, driven by a sudden impulse of desperation, grasped the doll’s shoulders firmly and called out, “Alice! Alice, can you hear me speaking?!”

To his astonishment, the doll ceased her repeating chant, her head turning slowly towards him as if the sound of her name had reached some part of her. A flicker of what seemed like recognition passed through her otherwise vacant eyes.

As the shrill noise and the vibrations subsided, the doll whispered, “Captain…”

Gazing directly into Duncan’s eyes, the doll’s voice emerged with the strained and stilted quality of a long-dormant machine stirring back to life, each word a laborious effort.

Then, with deliberate motions, she turned her head from side to side, as though recalibrating her systems. Following this adjustment, her speech flowed a bit more smoothly: “Captain, are you hungry?”

Duncan found himself at a loss for words.

The thought that this innocent doll would prioritize such a mundane concern upon regaining some semblance of consciousness was both bewildering and oddly touching.

“I’m not hungry. This isn’t the time for that,” Duncan replied, swiftly regaining his composure. The possibility of actually reviving some part of Alice’s awareness in this surreal setting seemed beyond belief, “Look around you. Do you understand the situation you’re currently in?”

It was only then that Alice seemed to fully register her surroundings, noticing for the first time that they were no longer aboard the familiar confines of the Vanished.

A fleeting expression of confusion crossed her features as she turned her puzzled gaze towards Duncan: “What place is this?”

Duncan paused, considering how best to explain the complex reality of their situation to Alice’s innocent consciousness. How could he describe that they were essentially inside “the core server room of the New Hope’s navigation chamber, which had been reimagined by the observers,” in a way she could comprehend? After a brief moment of thought, he took a decisive stance, grasping Alice’s shoulders firmly.

“This is the world inside your brain.”

Alice’s response was one of naive bewilderment: “But I don’t have a brain.”

The reply left Duncan momentarily speechless, struggling to find a response to her literal interpretation.

After a beat of stunned silence, he managed a stern reply: “Just pretend you do!”

“…Oh.”

Chapter 788: Analyzing the Star Map and the Uninvited Guest

Alice’s excitement was unmistakable, her eyes sparkled with amazement as she keenly observed every nuance of her environment. She appeared ready to rush into the enigmatic fog at the end of the hallway, only to be stopped in time by Duncan’s intervention. Pulling eagerly at Duncan’s arm, she flooded him with a barrage of inquiries about everything she saw, from the cables hanging above them to the mysteries concealed behind the doors they passed. Through Duncan’s patient explanations, Alice gradually learned that they were traversing a special section of the “Alice Mansion,” a discovery that exhilarated her. She treated this revelation as an extraordinary adventure.

“How fascinating… so this is the essence of the Alice Mansion,” Alice, with her doll-like appearance, remarked joyously. She explored the area around the platform where she initially stood, expressing her wonder, “Is this truly my home? It’s so vast! It’s just unfortunate I cannot reside here…”

“First off, we are currently exploring just a fragment of the Alice Mansion, specifically a grand hall within it,” Duncan elaborated, his eyes following Alice’s exploration. He felt compelled to clarify, “Additionally, not every Alice Mansion mirrors this one. For instance, in another variant of the Alice Mansion, you would find a garden in place of this hall. I surmise that accessing different Alice Mansions requires using distinct keys for opening varied doors.”

“Oh…” Alice responded, her nod indicating a partial understanding of Duncan’s detailed explanation.

Duncan’s focus then shifted to the drawing board Alice was clutching. This board was in her possession even before she had awakened, and she had instinctively continued to hold onto it. Recalling another version of the Alice Mansion, specifically the garden, where the doll had captured a catastrophic celestial event on her drawing board, Duncan became curious about the current contents of the board in her hands.

“Alice, may I have a look at your drawing board?” he inquired suddenly.

“Drawing board?” Alice appeared momentarily puzzled by the request but quickly realized she had been holding onto something. With enthusiasm, she approached Duncan and presented the drawing board, saying, “Here you go!”

Upon receiving the board, Duncan flipped it over, revealing not a drawing but a screen filled with an array of incomprehensible lines, symbols, and constantly refreshing data. It seemed to be engaged in intricate calculations and reconfigurations ceaselessly.

As Duncan studied the screen intently, a wave of speculation washed over him. At that moment, Alice, driven by curiosity, leaned in to get a better view. The unexpected revelation made her gasp in astonishment, leading to a prolonged exclamation, “I…”

Immediately recognizing the drawing board’s significance, Duncan urgently asked, “Do you comprehend what this represents?”

Without hesitation, Alice accurately described, “It pinpoints our location within the vast spatial and temporal structure of this refuge.” Then, without waiting for Duncan to ask more, she added with a touch of confidence, “What did I just say?”

Duncan was momentarily speechless. Ever since Alice's awakening, her remarks had increasingly left him uncertain about how to respond.

Yet, Alice's comment confirmed Duncan's suspicion: They had indeed uncovered the route.

The navigation key provided by the Leviathan Queen to unlock the "route" was indeed connected to this "doll" residing in the mansion, specifically through this "drawing board" she possessed!

Noting Duncan's thoughtful silence, Alice, tilting her head, expressed her bewilderment, "Captain? Why are you silent?"

Brought back to the moment by Alice's question, Duncan looked at her earnestly and posed a crucial inquiry, "Alice, if I'm correct, this 'route' leads us to the nodes of the external barrier. Are you capable of 'operating' it?"

Alice seemed momentarily perplexed, reclaiming the drawing board from Duncan and gently tracing her fingers across the screen's dynamic data and symbols. After pondering for a moment, she voiced her thoughts, as if thinking out loud, "I believe I… might understand? However, it seems I need to look deeper into it."

With a contemplative expression, she continued, "The operation method appears to be ingrained in my consciousness, as though I'm instinctively ready to initiate something, but fully comprehending it requires a bit more time… Don't worry, Captain, it won't be long."

As Alice shared her insights, Duncan's attention was diverted by a sudden activity. He glanced up to see the "tree" at the hall's center, composed entirely of intertwined cable conduits, beginning to animate —

Its "branches," illuminated by myriad twinkling lights, became more lively, uncovering numerous cables stretching toward the edges of the hall,

enveloped in mist. A low hum emerged from the mist, indicating the activation of some mechanism, its power gradually intensifying…

Alice's fingers gracefully navigated the drawing board, tracing the intricate lines and symbols displayed. As she did, data materialized out of thin air beside her, floating like ethereal figures. She became absorbed in her task, her concentration so deep that it seemed her entire being was immersed in the complexities of her work.

Unexpectedly, Duncan was startled by a voice that filled the hall. It was unmistakably Alice's voice, yet it emanated not directly from her but through an overhead broadcasting system:

"Main engine initiating… Star map analysis underway, authorization acknowledged by… Navigator One…"

Duncan watched the unfolding scene, a mix of astonishment and anticipation building within him. Just as he started to feel a surge of excitement, a sudden cacophony disrupted the tranquility. The luminous activity on the "tree" and the buzzing of machinery throughout the hall rapidly diminished.

"Analysis halted… Unauthorized access detected."

A wave of concern flickered across Duncan's eyes, reflecting a brief disorientation in Alice, who appeared momentarily taken aback. Then, as if emerging from a trance, she looked up, her expression one of sudden realization, "Captain, there's someone at the door!"

The idea of someone knocking seemed almost unfathomable.

Yet, Duncan's reaction was swift, and almost simultaneously with Alice's announcement, he detected the sound of knocking. It was not loud, but its clarity was undiminished by distance, reaching him as though no space separated them.

The knocking was persistent, its rhythm mechanical, devoid of any urgency yet relentless.

Clutching the drawing board closely, Alice leaped down from the platform, her actions betraying a hint of apprehension as she approached Duncan, “Captain, shall we respond to the door?”

After a moment of reflection, Duncan replied solemnly, “Follow me,” pausing to add, “Keep the drawing board with you at all times.”

“Oh… okay!” Alice’s reply was marked by a surge of anxious anticipation as she quickly aligned herself behind Duncan, moving toward the door.

Leaving the shadowed confines of the navigation hall, they ventured down the mansion’s extensive corridor. With Duncan leading, they passed silent rooms and porches, their pace brisk and purposeful as they approached the main hall on the ground floor.

Throughout, the knocking continued, a constant sound that seemed to resonate deeply within, unceasing in its persistence.

The sound of knocking momentarily transported Duncan back to memories of his solitary apartment and the mysterious visit from the Frost Queen amidst enveloping fog. He quickly set aside these wandering thoughts to concentrate on the pressing situation at hand.

With a firm grip on the drawing board, Alice quickened her pace to stay close to Duncan. She gazed around with wide-eyed curiosity at the grandeur of the mansion’s corridors, its slender windows, and secretive doors that seemed to whisper of mysteries locked away, her mind teeming with questions she had no time to ask due to the urgency of their task.

The sprawling complexity of the mansion was overwhelming. Alice came to the realization that without Duncan’s guidance, she could easily lose her way in its vast, winding passages.

After navigating through the intricate maze of hallways, they arrived at the grand entrance hall of the mansion.

There, at the end of the corridor, stood a daunting door, its significance amplified by the continuous knocking sounds resonating from the other side.

With a look of mild concern, Duncan made his way towards the door, Alice at his side. He attempted to sense any potential threats or intentions from the other side but was met with a puzzling silence; there were no signs of hostility, danger, or even the faintest hint of presence.

Though persistent, the knocking seemed to urge them to make a pivotal decision. Duncan recalled the headless butler's solemn warning—"Do not open the door at all costs, for beyond it lies the Great Annihilation"—and hesitated, his hand hovering over the doorknob.

Alice, though visibly anxious, maintained her trust in Duncan, clasping the drawing board as though it were an anchor in this sea of uncertainty, her gaze locked on the formidable door before them.

As Duncan's hands made contact with the door, it let out a creak of protest yet surprisingly gave way with ease. Despite its daunting appearance and the eerie sound it made, the door opened smoothly as if it had been eagerly awaiting their approach.

With the door now ajar, a flood of sunlight pierced the darkness, washing over Duncan and Alice in a warm, welcoming light, revealing a new reality beyond the threshold that they had never anticipated.

In the midst of the emptiness outside, a radiant sun shone brightly, its luminous rays enveloping the entrance of the Alice Mansion in a dazzling brilliance. Remarkably, despite the intensity of the sunlight, it felt soothing to their eyes, causing no discomfort.

A strange familiarity washed over Duncan as he took in the sight of the sun, which soon began to shift its position in the sky, its blazing corona gradually dimming to reveal the truth hidden beneath its fiery exterior.

Beneath its scorching guise, an ancient deity emerged, a disturbing fusion of pallid, decaying tentacles and swollen flesh that formed a celestial being. At the heart of what seemed to be a sun, this entity featured a massive eye amidst its tentacles, slowly directing its focus towards Duncan and Alice, who stood on the brink of the mansion.

This entity was known as the “Black Sun,” not just a cosmic phenomenon but a revered figure among the Suntists as the “True Black Sun”—and this very entity had been knocking.

Before Duncan could process his thoughts into words, a feeble voice echoed, not through the air but directly into their minds. The ancient god, its appearance marked by the toll of its luminance, spoke in a voice layered with exhaustion, “I was on the verge of abandoning my attempt to reach you.”

Caught off guard and momentarily lost for words, Duncan observed the deity. Its eye, challenging ordinary perceptions of distance and scale, scrutinized them intently, “Navigating from the depths of the mansion to the door is no small feat, especially in response to your knock.”

Hearing Duncan’s observation, Alice promptly concurred, voicing her agreement with genuine enthusiasm, “That’s right, it’s vast! Our journey here felt like it took forever!”

The cosmic entity fell silent for a brief moment as if mulling over their statements. After a short pause, it acknowledged their explanation with a simple acknowledgment, “Hmm, that explains it.”

Chapter 789: The Rotting Black Sun

In the vast, empty void of space, Duncan gazed at the sun, a celestial body he had always associated with light and warmth. However, in a startling revelation, he realized it was no more than a mere shadow in this emptiness. This epiphany came swiftly, altering his perception drastically. Despite its grandeur, the entity before him, which he knew as the “Creeping Sun wheel,” provided neither warmth nor the comforting presence of life. To him, it was hollow, a distant echo of something far more profound, reminiscent of his first encounter with it through the “Golden Mask.”

Duncan pondered over this enigma, the “True Black Sun,” which had somehow pinpointed the Alice Mansion’s location to project its illusory presence. What had drawn its attention? Was it Duncan’s own arrival or the disturbances caused by Alice’s navigational endeavors?

With a mind brimming with curiosity yet tempered by caution, Duncan inquired, “How did you find this place?” His voice, careful yet devoid of hostility, reflected his complex history with the followers and descendants of the Black Sun—a history marked by challenges but ultimately shaped by understanding and empathy. Duncan had come to recognize that the intentions of this ancient deity were never malevolent towards the mortal realm.

Unlike other ancient gods, this deity had been metaphorically simmered over a gentle flame by its own worshippers and progeny. If it were capable

of expression, the “True Black Sun” might have labeled itself as “tragic” on each of its tendrils…

“I ‘heard’ the disturbances from subspace. Navigator Three… after years of dormancy, suddenly activated, signaling the approach of a significant moment,” the sun, marred and misshapen, revealed. Despite its weakened state, there was a softness in its voice, “Usurper, our paths cross once again.”

“The approach of a significant moment… You anticipated my arrival?” Duncan seized upon the sun’s statement, his concern evident, “And you’re aware of Navigator Three?”

“…I am also ‘one of them,’” the Creeping Sun wheel responded, its pace measured, “Before the birth of a new sun by Navigator One, I played a role in this sanctuary’s creation.”

Duncan paused, his gaze laden with reflection.

He then spoke, his voice resonating with a clarity of purpose, “What do you seek from me? Do you still harbor hope that I might assist in ending your existence? If so, I must confess, I’m currently preoccupied—your ‘progeny’ and ‘adherents’ persist in reigniting your flames, and my ability to intervene is limited at this time…”

Before Duncan could fully articulate his thoughts, the disfigured sun interjected, its voice trembling once more: “Concern for my offspring… or the mortals who worship the ‘Black Sun’ is no longer necessary.”

Duncan’s demeanor shifted, his eyebrows furrowing as he sought clarity, “What do you mean by that?”

The sun’s response was both shocking and disconcerting: “The faith in the True Black Sun has dissipated from this realm. The Black Sun will soon be forgotten, its stories and records transforming into ambiguous, distorted

‘impressions,’ eventually replaced by semblances that mimic reality yet are mere illusions. Usurper, should you doubt these words, you have the means to verify them within the mortal realm. I trust in your capabilities to do so.”

The significance of these revelations dawned heavily on Duncan, his expression growing more solemn. He contemplated the implications, breaking the silence with a poignant question, “…What happened? Why has it come to this?”

He considered the possibility that the “True Black Sun” could no longer bear the burden of its slow demise and had eradicated all traces of its offspring, remnants, and worshippers. Yet, the idea of memories and records fading into oblivion, replaced by illusions, suggested a scenario far more complex than mere annihilation—it hinted at the corruption of history itself.

Observing the entity before him, Duncan noted its writhing tendrils and the flesh engulfed by its aura, which spoke with a voice tinged with sorrow, “I am rotting. After enduring for ages, my end is imminent.”

The concept of “rotting” struck a chord with Duncan, echoing previous mentions by various entities. Now, the “True Black Sun” brought it up as well.

“As all things associated with ‘me’ begin to fade, so does the world’s memory of me,” the deformed sun continued, its tone reflective. “My homeland’s visage, the faces and names of those key to my creation—those who were part of my essence—are fading. They are relics of the ‘Old World,’ vital to my existence.”

“Usurper, it’s uncertain if you can fully grasp what I’m conveying—my essence is eroding, and this disintegration is the final stage of decay.”

Duncan remained thoughtful, absorbing the profound revelations shared with him. After a moment, he ventured, “…So, you’re suggesting that your

self-awareness and memories are involuntarily fading, erasing everything tied to your self-awareness and memories from this world… Is this the essence of your ‘rot’?”

“Precisely as you’ve deduced—it’s a gradual process,” the deformed sun replied, its voice now carrying an even greater weight of frailty. “Since arriving in this ‘world,’ our decay had begun. This type of rot has been a constant throughout the sanctuary’s history…”

The deformed sun shared its sorrowful truth with Duncan, revealing the tragic nature of its existence. “Unfortunately, the part of us capable of rational thought remains conscious during this ordeal. I am painfully aware of what I’m ‘forgetting,’ even as those elements vanish from my being. I understand what those lost aspects represented, but such ‘memories’ are now futile. The remnants of our past, brought from the old world, continue to disintegrate, becoming unrecognizable scraps…”

“This is my reality, and it applies to the entities known as the four gods as well. They, too, are experiencing this decline…”

“Usurper, over the years, I’ve endured several ‘intensifications’ of decay, with the fading of the ‘Black Sun’s’ legacy possibly marking its most severe and final phase. My time is swiftly depleting.”

Having conveyed so much, the deformed sun seemed to lose the strength to continue, its voice fading into silence.

Duncan, his brows knitting together in concern, began to understand the concept of “rot” as it pertained to the gods, linking it to various observations. Yet, his immediate focus was on the intentions behind the Black Sun’s revelations.

“You’ve sought me out, clearly not just to impart this knowledge. What do you wish for me to do?”

After a moment of silence, the voice of the Black Sun reached Duncan and Alice, carrying a solemn request: “I implore you to end my existence… However, when that day comes, I ask that you consume my remains with your flames, reduce them to ashes, and then, remember those remains.”

The notion of burning to ashes and holding onto memories intrigued Duncan, prompting a moment of insight.

“…It seems you’ve gleaned some understanding of my ‘power,’” he acknowledged, his tone grave.

“I have vigilantly observed this sanctuary for eons, enduring the ceaseless decay and isolation that have limited my actions, yet I have remained acutely aware of the myriad events transpiring within this realm—including those involving you,” the Black Sun articulated with a measured pace, its voice imbued with a profound sense of purpose. “My desire… is to cement a legacy.”

Duncan, absorbing the weight of these words, repeated, “A legacy in a ‘new world’…” His expression remained thoughtful, a mix of skepticism and curiosity coloring his response. “Your request sparks interest. Yet, how can you be so confident that your actions will ensure a ‘place in the new world’? Furthermore, how can you be so sure that a ‘new world’ will indeed materialize?”

His gaze hardened, signifying the gravity of his inquiry, “You must understand, while I do harbor plans to reconstruct everything following the sanctuary’s demise, certainty of success eludes me—I’m still in the process of devising a viable strategy… And yet, you approach with such a proposal, aspiring to secure a spot?”

“At the core of our agreement,” the entity before Duncan, a conglomerate of pale, shifting flesh, began to transform subtly. Slender tentacles protruded from the radiant aura enveloping it, reaching out as though in

search of something unseen, highlighting the seriousness of its proposition. “Should you grant my request, I am willing to offer you a glimpse into the future, a preview that will undoubtedly serve as a boon in your journey.”

Duncan found himself ensnared by curiosity.

“You claim to have ‘proof’?” His keen gaze dissected the throbbing entity, “Do you imply you possess evidence that validates a successful transition into this ‘new world’ is feasible?”

A momentary silence ensued, after which the Black Sun offered a mysterious response: “At present, I do not.”

Duncan, momentarily thrown, pondered if the ancient being was jesting. Yet, he quickly regained his composure. Given his extensive encounters with the myriad enigmas and inconceivable phenomena at reality’s brink, he began to discern the significance behind the entity’s statement.

“And how is this ‘proof’ supposed to manifest?”

“It will materialize once you heed my appeal,” the Black Sun declared with a deliberate pace.

Duncan lapsed into contemplation, weighing his options.

“You are free to take your time over my offer,” the voice of the Black Sun resonated with a patient tone as the tendrils retracted into the fiery aura surrounding it. “I recognize your hesitancy and the skepticism you harbor—the ‘Black Sun’ has indeed been the source of many a catastrophe in this world, and while I may not pose as your foe, I have yet to earn your trust.”

Then, Duncan shifted the dialogue, probing deeper with a query, “Is it a place for yourself you seek? For the ‘offspring’ now faded from your memory? Or is it for something else entirely…”

“For our civilization,” replied the Black Sun, its voice now a mere whisper, laden with nostalgia, “A civilization that once flourished.”

Through this exchange, the ancient entity, the Black Sun, conveyed its deep-seated desire not only for the cessation of its existence but for the preservation of its legacy within the fabric of a potential new world. Faced with the weight of this request, Duncan found himself at a crossroads between skepticism and the potential for unforeseen possibilities, pondering the implications of their impending agreement.

Chapter 790: The Rotting Future

In a vast expanse of turmoil, a grotesque, deformed sun burned silently, its eerie glow casting light on clusters of flesh that formed malevolent “stars,” a far cry from their original identities.

This ominous entity goes by several names: The Black Sun, the Creeping Sun Wheel, the True Black Sun, among others. Speculation abounds about its origins. Was it once a genuine star, encased in a Dyson sphere by a now-extinct civilization, or is the sphere itself a remnant of that civilization, serving as the sole evidence of its former glory?

Among the many bizarre entities Duncan has encountered in this realm, the Black Sun is undoubtedly the most singular “Old God” he has come across. It symbolizes the amalgamation of a once-great civilization and its nurturing star, now fused into this aberrant form. This fusion may account for its decay proceeding at a pace faster than that of other Old Gods, its essence unraveling from the moment of its transformation.

Despite the Black Sun’s pleas, Duncan remains wary, sensing hidden depths and secrets within this twisted celestial body that perhaps even the Four Gods are unaware of, which keeps him on alert.

For now, the Black Sun holds back its secrets, and Duncan is not inclined to probe further. The Black Sun has hinted at an impending end but suggests there is still time for contemplation, understanding, and building trust.

“I cannot agree to your request at this moment,” Duncan communicated, expressing his reservations, “I lack sufficient knowledge about you, and more critically, I’m unsure about your plan for reshaping the world. Until I gain clarity on these matters, I cannot pledge my support.”

“That is understandable,” came a deep, resonant reply from within the Black Sun, its voice vibrating with layers of sound, “Then take the time to validate your plan, find your path… You will seek me out again, of that I am certain.”

Duncan, curious, inquired, “Will you maintain this ‘projection’ here at all times? So, if I need to consult with you, I should return to this specific location?”

“The sanctum of the refuge limits my influence, and forcing entry would harm the mortal realm – but here, my presence is unrestricted, free from consequences,” the Black Sun patiently explained, “I will maintain this projection. As long as you’re in the ‘borderlands,’ you can reach out to me… I will be listening.”

Duncan nodded in acknowledgment: “Understood.”

In the midst of this chaotic void, the Black Sun momentarily trembled before regaining its calm. Although Duncan had not agreed to its proposal, the entity seemed to accept this non-committal stance as a satisfactory temporary resolution. Its corona gently enveloped itself, and its massive singular eye, partially obscured by flesh, closed in a semblance of rest.

“It’s so quiet…” Duncan was caught off guard by the soft, dreamlike utterance of the deformed sun, “It has been ages since I’ve felt this kind of ‘quiet’… Even the searing flames now feel bearable.”

Understanding the nature of the ‘quiet’ being referred to, Duncan observed with a complex expression, “…you can no longer hear the prayers and

sacrifices offered to you."

"Yes, it's as if they never existed," the Black Sun responded gently, "This might be the respite I've longed for."

Duncan tried to discern any emotion in its tone, pondering whether the Black Sun felt relief or perhaps a hint of sorrow, but the voice was too serene to reveal anything definitive.

He contemplated the nature of divine decay and ventured, "…When the 'rot' reaches its peak, what becomes of you? Do you simply cease to exist? Or do you linger in a state where you're disconnected from everything, forgotten by the world, as you described?"

"I don't know, as no Old God has fully succumbed to decay, and the final outcome remains a mystery," the Black Sun answered slowly, "But it's expected that the refuge world will continue to 'fade' along with us…"

"Long ago, we used our collective memories, born from the ashes of great cataclysms, to create the 'materials' for constructing the sanctuary as you know it. As the gods decay, the refuge, built from these 'materials,' will also deteriorate – symbolizing the gradual erasure of all memory of the old world as we disintegrate."

"One day, the ocean will forget how to form waves, life will lose the concept of death, flames will not know how to burn, wind will stop blowing, clouds will fall from the sky to the sea… even if the 'sun' created by Navigator One rises again, it won't stop the collapse that begins at the very foundation of the world…"

Duncan absorbed these profound words, his thoughts drifting to the palace on the black stone island, recalling the Leviathan Queen who died alone within its walls.

To protect the real world from her “decay,” she isolated her “end” within the palace’s temporal flow, but now, even that isolation has ended.

“This feels like an end as obscure and lightless as the last flicker of a flame,” Duncan commented, his voice tinged with emotion.

“The end of time is inherently dim and lightless, just as the brightest stars eventually cool and fade,” the Black Sun replied gently, “Moreover, since the refuge world was created, the ‘rot’ of the gods has been an integral part of its history, with realities continuously eroding away from the true dimension. Who could notice… they have already vanished.”

Duncan contemplated these words, a chill running through him as he grasped the full implications of the Black Sun’s statement: “…What exactly are you suggesting?”

After a pause, the Black Sun asked, “Do you remember how many intelligent races once thrived in the Boundless Sea?”

Duncan’s thoughts briefly clouded, but he instinctively replied, “I thought there were four…”

He hesitated, sensing something amiss with that number.

“Which four?” the Black Sun pressed, its voice calm yet profound.

Duncan fell silent, the realization hitting him with profound clarity, leaving him speechless.

After a short pause, the Black Sun continued, its tone steady, “You recall their existence but not their names or appearances. I, too, remember they existed but can no longer picture them… because the entities responsible for preserving their memory have been ‘decaying’, and ultimately, the world ‘corrected’ this by erasing their memory, reducing the lifespan of the sanctuary.”

“Usurper, this is our world’s reality. It has happened before and continues now, with the ‘Black Sun’ disappearing from the world’s view being just a minor aspect of this widespread disintegration.”

“There’s no need for grief, for death and oblivion have always unfolded this way.”

…

As the door of Alice’s Mansion creaked shut, sealing away the external world, the artificial sunlight vanished as if it had never been there.

The mansion’s tall, slender windows were covered in grime, with thorn-like shadows blocking any light. Sunlight seemed a distant concept, visible only when the main door was open.

Duncan returned to the dim hall, standing in the unusual quiet for a long time before exhaling softly.

Beside him, Alice remained silent while she looked anxiously towards the door, her unease evident.

She seemed eager to ask questions but unsure what to ask.

“I couldn’t follow your conversation with the ‘Black Sun’,” she admitted, scratching her head, “But your demeanor suggests it was serious, right Captain?”

Duncan turned to Miss Doll, his expression softening after a moment.

“It’s fine if you didn’t understand,” he reassured her, stroking Alice’s hair gently, “These are concerns for me to reflect on.”

“Oh,” Alice said, her expression showing a glimmer of understanding before quickly shifting to another question, “So, are you considering the Black Sun’s proposal? About the location of that… new world or whatever it was.”

Despite not fully grasping the exchange with the Black Sun, she understood that it had made a request of Duncan.

Duncan paused thoughtfully under Miss Doll's watchful eye. "I'm not certain yet, but the 'new world' it mentioned, holding some evidence of it, intrigues me," he mused, "And there's something else that has caught my attention even more…"

Alice's curiosity was piqued: "What else?"

"The true form of the Black Sun," Duncan disclosed, directing Alice's curious gaze with his hand, "My interest in that is growing."

Alice processed his words, her face a mix of understanding and bewilderment: "So… are we going to search for its real form?"

"No," Duncan responded with a gentle smile, "That's a task for another day; we have more pressing issues to address."

"Pressing issues?"

Duncan's face showed a mixture of feelings: "…Remember the decoding we need to do?"

"Oh, right!" Alice exclaimed, as realization hit her.

Chapter 791: Sailors Farewell

A fog hung over the ocean like a delicate veil, shrouding the mysterious islands that lay beyond the ship's railing. The sea remained tranquil, in stark contrast to the enigmatic ancient temple that had once stood imposingly in the distance, now entirely obscured by the fog, as though it had never been there, to begin with.

On the ship's stern deck, Sailor found himself seated atop a wooden barrel, his eyes fixated on the haunting mist at the horizon. He was so engrossed in his thoughts that he seemed to be in a trance.

The quiet was suddenly broken by the sound of footsteps approaching, pulling Sailor out of his deep contemplation. He turned, his body stiff as if he were more of a statue than a living person, to see who was coming, lifting his eyes to meet theirs.

"Miss Vanna, good afternoon," he greeted her, a hint of sadness in his voice, "Ah, you're really tall."

"That's something I often hear," Vanna responded casually, taking a seat on a barrel next to him. She looked out at the captivating fog that had so thoroughly entranced Sailor, "Agatha mentioned you've been here all day. What's been on your mind?"

"I'm not entirely sure," Sailor admitted, sounding a bit puzzled as he shook his head. "Just lost in thought, I suppose. In this state, there's not much else I can do. No need for food, drink, or sleep – and there's hardly any manual

labor required on this ship. It seems to run itself quite efficiently. The most we ever seem to do is clean up after Miss Alice's chaos…"

Vanna listened quietly, allowing Sailor to speak his mind. Though he seldom spoke since they arrived on the Vanished, when he did share his thoughts, they flowed freely, making one wonder if he had always been this way, even in life.

As Sailor eventually trailed off, Vanna offered a kind smile and shook her head gently, "You shouldn't talk like that in front of Alice. It would break her heart."

"Ah, I know. I wouldn't dream of it," Sailor quickly reassured her, his expression becoming a complex mix of emotions, "Besides… I probably won't get the chance to say it, anyway."

Vanna looked at him with curiosity but chose to remain silent.

Sailor's gaze returned to the fog, towards where the temple once stood.

"…You hear it too, don't you? The gentle sound of the waves," he suddenly said.

Vanna appeared slightly surprised, but before she could respond, Sailor continued, seemingly indifferent to her reaction, "Since we set sail, I've occasionally heard it – the whispers among the waves, speaking in languages I don't understand. They seem to communicate with me, just as I am now sharing my thoughts with you… Is it wrong, do you think, to speak this way?"

"That's a blessing from the Goddess," Vanna answered, pausing for a moment as if choosing her words carefully. "She's aware of your presence. Her voice naturally reaches those who have faith in Her."

"But I've lost my memory of Her," Sailor said quietly, a note of sorrow in his voice. "I remember arriving here, something important happening, but

the days I spent as a priest in the Storm Church, offering prayers, seem to belong to someone else. It appears I can no longer be considered a follower. It's been two centuries since I last prayed to Her."

"The Goddess might not be in your current memories, but you are certainly in Hers," Vanna replied with a firm belief, her faith unwavering. "The Goddess remembers each of Her children, even those lost for centuries like you. As the 'Storm Codex' teaches us, prayer is just one form of connection; our true bond with the Goddess goes beyond rituals."

Sailor looked at her with renewed respect, "Your faith is strong."

Vanna's expression softened, showing a hint of curiosity, "Do I not seem like a devout believer usually?"

Sailor decided not to delve into that question further.

"I'm nearing the end of my journey," he suddenly said, his voice carrying a sense of finality. "The captain has plotted a new course, and it seems my services are no longer needed."

Vanna's face showed she was about to say something, but she paused, allowing Sailor to continue uninterrupted: "After this last mission, it's probably time for me to leave the ship. I'll take nothing with me. These old robes and coats belong to a past era, destined to fade away just like me. So, you don't need to worry about settling any affairs for me, just…"

His words were cut off by a commanding yet calm voice from behind: "Just what?"

Startled, Sailor quickly turned around, and Vanna also stood, turning towards the source of the voice.

"Captain, you've returned," Vanna said with a mixture of relief and complexity in her tone, nodding towards Duncan before looking back at Sailor with concern, "Captain, Sailor, he…"

Duncan raised his hand, indicating he had overheard their conversation, and focused on Sailor, “Go on, you were saying ‘just’ what?”

Encouraged by Captain Duncan’s steady gaze, Sailor began to speak more openly than he had before, “Just feel sorry for Captain Lawrence—I left abruptly, without a proper goodbye, without hinting I might never come back. The crew of the White Oak probably still waits for my return…”

He paused, then offered a smile filled with both regret and freedom, embodying his complex feelings.

“Could you relay a message for me? Just let them know that ‘Sailor’ was proud to serve on the White Oak, even if it was for a brief period. Despite the constant noise and chaos, it was truly the happiest time in my recent memory.”

“I don’t have any personal belongings to leave behind, but please extend my apologies to Gus, the White Oak’s first mate. I regret that the two pounds of fine tobacco I owe him will likely go unpaid. And not just to him, but also to the second mate, the boatswain, the stoker, the engineer, and the priest…”

He paused, counting off a few names on his fingers before spreading his hands wide, a rueful smile on his face. “Gambling never ends well, does it? This includes bets against people. I had also planned to leave something for you. I intended to write you a letter and slip away quietly. There are things that always felt too awkward to say in person. But, as you can see, things don’t always go as planned…”

As Sailor shared his thoughts under Duncan’s understanding gaze, he took a deep breath – a gesture more symbolic than necessary, given his lack of need for oxygen, blending with the surrounding mist.

Facing Duncan, Sailor’s expression became serious, his eyes conveying a depth of sincerity that hadn’t been there before. “I am truly honored. Despite my initial fears, I am deeply grateful for the brief time I spent with the Vanished.”

“You are the greatest explorer and captain of our era. I’m convinced that whatever you aim to achieve, you will succeed. I don’t have proof, nor do I understand prophecies, but I have a strong feeling… Whatever you seek, you will find it.”

“So, if there really is a new world out there, I hope you’ll remember the story of the Sea Song and share it with those yet to come. Let them know that, in the twilight of our world, there was a crew who gave their all.”

“And finally, thank you. Thank you for everything you’ve done so far, and for continuing to try to save this world… Though it feels cold and twisted to me now, I vaguely remember it once being a good place.”

With that, Sailor’s voice remained steady, his earlier hesitation and remorse dissipating like fog in the sun.

He then bowed deeply to Duncan, showing the utmost respect and gratitude, and upon straightening up, he turned to Vanna, drawing the symbol of the waves across his chest with his right hand.

Vanna, visibly moved, stepped forward as though she wanted to reach out, but instead, she simply reflected the symbol back to him, a silent exchange of understanding and respect.

“Are you sure you want to leave?” Duncan asked, locking eyes with Sailor.

“You’ve come back, so it’s time for me to move on,” Sailor replied with a serene smile, taking a few steps back. “I’ll find a peaceful place to rest. It’s been a long time since I’ve truly rested.”

Duncan nodded, his silence a solemn acceptance of Sailor’s decision.

Sailor walked across the deck, disappearing into the thick fog that had quietly enveloped the ship. His form faded into the mist, eventually vanishing from sight entirely, leaving Duncan and Vanna in a poignant silence.

After a moment, Vanna, unable to stand the silence any longer, turned to Duncan, her voice carrying a mix of emotions, “Captain…”

Duncan raised his hand to pause further conversation, then posed a thought-provoking question, “Vanna, do you know how many times a person can truly face death?”

This question caught Vanna off-guard, hinting at a deeper meaning. She remained silent, her gaze lingering on the place where Sailor had disappeared, perhaps hoping for one last glimpse of him. Eventually, she turned her attention back to Duncan, ready to move the conversation forward, “Captain, what are our next steps?”

Acknowledging her readiness, Duncan walked towards the ship’s helm at the stern, signaling a readiness to continue their journey without looking back. “We have much more to explore. The Vanished will chart a new course – Alice is ready, and now, we’ll test her ‘navigation’ skills for the first time.”

Vanna, understanding the shift in focus, followed Duncan promptly.

At the helm, Alice stood beside the wheel, visibly anxious as she awaited further instructions from Duncan. The mop, bucket, ropes, spare iron hooks, and other deck items seemed to anticipate the significance of the moment, congregating around the helm as if drawn by an unseen force, ready to witness the unfolding events.

A rope gently nudged Alice’s leg, offering reassurance or perhaps seeking comfort for itself.

Admitting her apprehension, Alice whispered, “I’m a bit nervous…” Despite Duncan’s reassurances, her voice betrayed her anxiety, “Even though the captain said it’s okay, I can’t help but worry…”

The ropes, bucket, and other items nearby responded with a cacophony of clattering and rustling, their movements creating a symphony of sounds that, to Alice, felt like the voices of her ‘friends’, each expressing their own nervousness.

It was clear that Alice wasn’t alone in her feelings; the entire ship seemed to be holding its breath, bracing for what was to come.

Chapter 792: Alices Liberation

When Duncan and Vanna ventured towards the stern of the ship, they stumbled upon a scene that was as bizarre as it was unexpected. Miss Alice was found in a peculiar position, nestled awkwardly among a disarray of ropes and buckets right next to the steering wheel, deeply engaged in an activity that seemed quite out of the ordinary. At first glance, she appeared to be talking to herself, a solitary figure amidst the maritime clutter. However, driven by an innate curiosity, Duncan moved closer, almost on tiptoe, to better understand the situation. To his astonishment, he discovered that Alice wasn't merely talking to herself; instead, she was offering what seemed like psychological counseling to the inanimate objects surrounding her.

The core of her counseling session revolved around a strange confession: "Even though I have no idea how to steer this ship, there's really no reason for us to panic. The fact that I'm not familiar with navigation comes from an honest understanding of my own limitations."

Duncan had been hesitant about the idea of leaving Alice alone on the deck. Now, having witnessed this peculiar behavior, his concern grew, convinced that her actions were contributing to an underlying tension that seemed to permeate the entire ship.

It was at this moment that Alice noticed Duncan's presence. She quickly untangled herself from the cluster of buckets and ropes, stood up, and warmly greeted him with a wave, exclaiming, "Captain! You've come!"

Duncan’s reply was a subdued “Hmm,” marked by a solemn expression. He made a conscious effort to overlook the odd phenomenon of the objects seemingly shifting on their own, choosing instead to direct his focus towards Alice. “Are you still feeling nervous?” he inquired.

“Just a little,” Alice responded, her bashfulness evident in her nod. Yet, her demeanor soon brightened with a smile. “But I’m feeling much better now! I’ve had a meaningful conversation with my friends here. It turns out they were also feeling a bit anxious, which made me feel less alone with my nerves…”

Observing this unusual interaction with a mix of confusion and amusement, Vanna said, “Do you understand why they’re feeling anxious?”

“Not the faintest idea,” Alice replied, her voice tinged with a note of contentment. “They didn’t go into specifics, but they assured me they’re keeping a positive outlook.”

Vanna was momentarily speechless at Alice’s answer, while Duncan sighed, his expression one of resigned acceptance. He then offered Alice reassurance, “Don’t dwell on it too much, and don’t be concerned. Goathead and I will monitor the situation on the ship. Remember, your role here at the helm is symbolic. Do you recall our earlier discussion?”

Alice’s expression turned thoughtful as she recalled her time with Duncan at the “Alice Mansion,” the feeling of holding the “drawing board” amidst an eerie black fog, and then she nodded solemnly at Duncan. “Yes, I remember. You advised me to hold onto that sensation while at the wheel, to treat it as my ‘drawing board’ and to ‘transmit’ all my memories to the Vanished, right?”

“That’s correct,” Duncan confirmed. “This approach is inspired by the feedback we received from Sailor during our navigation of the ship. But at this point, we’re still unsure if the Vanished is able to ‘understand’ the

instructions you’re giving, since the information you and Sailor have documented isn’t completely aligned.”

“Understood,” Alice replied, her nod full of determination. “So, we’re about to conduct a preliminary test, correct? To see if I can truly connect with the ship before we leave this place.”

Quietly, Duncan and Vanna moved to the side of the control deck, their eyes lingering on the essence of the Vanished. In a silent exchange with the ship’s somewhat restless “consciousness,” Duncan remained concentrated until he was confident that the Vanished was ready for the next steps. He then subtly nodded to Alice, who was stationed by the steering wheel, signaling, “It’s time to begin, Alice.”

Sensing the significance of the moment, Miss Doll advanced cautiously and took a deep breath. Though unnecessary for a doll, this action served as a symbolic mimic of a deep, calming breath, a human technique to steady one’s nerves before a daunting task.

The steering wheel before her, dark and foreboding, silently awaited her touch, presenting a challenge she had never imagined facing.

Alice paused, reflecting on the surreal nature of her current predicament. Despite not possessing vast intelligence, her thoughts often drifted to far-off places. Yet, she had never envisioned herself in this position, assuming the role of a captain and taking control of the steering wheel of the Vanished.

This responsibility, bestowed upon her by Duncan, was not to be questioned. Filled with a mixture of apprehension and anticipation, yet devoid of doubt, Alice reached out, her fingers wrapping around the wheel that felt as though it bore the entire weight of the night sky.

At that moment, Alice’s perception of the world around her transformed dramatically.

Her “eyes” widened in astonishment as she experienced a disconnection from her doll body, only to realize she had merged into a new “body” – she felt as if she was floating in the ocean, enveloped by a fog, her hull gently caressed by the cold, calm waters, her deck illuminated by the faint glow of the sky, her invisible sails at the mercy of the spirit world, ready for the journey that lay ahead.

Alice had become one with the Vanished; she was now the ship in its entirety – its rudder, its sails, its deck, its ropes. These ropes, akin to the strings that control a puppet or the nerves that weave through a human body, represented countless thoughts and connections.

In this bewildering state, Alice marveled at the transformation of her “body,” feeling a deep connection with these threads. It was then that she realized something she had previously overlooked: The Vanished possessed a soul, intertwined with these very threads.

While it had always kept its “threads” hidden, now, with Duncan’s permission, Alice was granted the ability to perceive them.

Overwhelmed with joy and an insatiable curiosity, Alice’s consciousness roamed this vast new body, exploring every corner with zeal. She discovered parts of the ship beyond her previous awareness, including Duncan’s private quarters and sections of the ship’s underbelly, which remained hidden from her. Yet, even without access to these hidden areas, Alice uncovered numerous secrets previously unknown to her – unexplored rooms, locked cabins, and concealed passageways and levels known only to Duncan…

But suddenly, Alice’s joyful exploration was abruptly halted by an unexpected force, as if she had collided with an unseen barrier within the intricate “ship-shaped network” created by myriad delicate threads. In that

instant, halted by what seemed to be a collision with one or possibly two entities, Alice's journey came to an unexpected pause.

Confused and slightly disoriented within the dimly lit expanse created by the fine threads, Alice encountered a figure she recognized: Goathead.

Goathead seemed to float in the void, his expression as perplexed as Alice's.

Their mutual confusion lingered in the silence between them until Goathead, appearing almost like a phantom and semi-transparent, broke the stillness with an exclamation of surprise, "What's this!?"

"Mr. Goathead!" Alice exclaimed, her voice filled with delight at their meeting. She instinctively wanted to wave in greeting, but then remembered that her current form was merely a consciousness within a different vessel. Instead, she shouted, "The captain has allowed me to steer!"

"I can see you're at the helm," Goathead replied, still visibly perplexed. As someone who had always monitored the entire condition of the ship, he had never anticipated encountering an anomaly within the "spirit" of the Vanished – a wandering "entity." Curious, yet inadvertently colliding with the adventurous doll, he inquired, "But why are you here?"

"I'm not entirely sure," Alice answered honestly, "Isn't this part of steering? And may I ask, why are you here?"

"I've been intertwined with this ship for a century, growing alongside it. Why do you think I'm here?" Goathead's eyes narrowed as he scrutinized the doll before him, which to him appeared as a cluster of phantom light. "And who told you that steering involved immersing your soul into the ship's essence? You're moving around so carelessly; aren't you concerned about colliding with someone…"

Alice paused, her thoughts racing before a realization dawned on her. “Under normal circumstances, would you encounter someone within the ship’s ‘soul’?”

Goathead remained silent, offering no reply.

“But I did encounter someone,” Alice quickly changed the subject before Goathead could respond, her voice a mixture of surprise and embarrassment. “And it felt as though it wasn’t just you I ran into… It seemed like there was also a fleeting shadow…”

As she contemplated this aloud, a weak and aggrieved voice emerged from the void: “It was me…”

Startled, Alice then realized that indeed, amidst the dark chaos around her, several discordant and eerie shadows lingered, drifting like fragmented echoes among the threads and the faint silhouette of the Vanished. Shortly thereafter, the most prominent shadow began to stir. As smaller shadows swiftly merged and reformed, a human figure emerged from the darkness.

Agatha, adjusting her adventurer’s coat and smoothing out her appearance to regain her human form, shot a glare at the doll. Her presence added another layer of complexity to the already enigmatic situation Alice found herself in.

Agatha, typically known for her affable demeanor, expressed her annoyance with an unusual sharpness, “You just rolled right over me! Shattered me into pieces! Do you really need to move around so recklessly?”

Alice, taken aback, glanced at Agatha and then turned to look at Goathead, finding herself unexpectedly privy to another layer of the ship’s intricate internal dynamics. After the captain, she was now the second crew member to gain insight into the “First Mate” and the “Lookout’s” unique and vibrant existence aboard the ship.

Opting to momentarily revel in this revelation, Alice responded with a playful, “…Well, well.”

This remark quickly stirred both Goathead and Agatha’s frustrations.

Their attention then returned to Alice, observing her with a blend of curiosity and concern.

“Your current state… is quite remarkable,” Agatha remarked, scrutinizing Alice, who now seemed to be an integral part of the Vanished, with a mix of astonishment and analytical interest. Drawing upon her expertise as a former gatekeeper, she examined Alice’s “mental phantom” with a professional eye. “So, is this your ‘essence’? Or rather… is it closer to your true essence?”

Pondering the question, Alice inquired, “What do you mean?”

Agatha elaborated, “…It suggests that your usual form has been constraining you, and now, being merged with the Vanished, this more powerful ‘vessel’ has granted you a new level of ‘freedom’.” She patiently explained to Alice, now accustomed to her transformed appearance, “Have you noticed this yourself?”

Alice’s realization dawned upon her, her dimly glowing form in the void expressing a sense of elation: “Yes, I feel light and liberated, though there’s always this nagging sensation that I feel…”

“Always feel what?” Goathead and Agatha asked in unison, their interest piqued.

Alice hesitated, then confessed with a thoughtful pause, “Always feel… something isn’t quite right,” slowly “looking up” as she spoke, “This isn’t my body; that… is.”

Both Goathead and Agatha, momentarily taken aback by Alice’s statement, instinctively raised their gaze skyward.

A massive, fragmented shadow, larger and more imposing than the vague silhouette of the Vanished, loomed ominously over the chaotic expanse, having emerged into their consciousness without prior notice.

“…Damn!”

Chapter 793: Temporary Communication

The scene began to subtly change as a massive, undefined structure started to form near the Vanished.

Duncan, who was stationed at the stern's helm, was intently monitoring Alice's condition. However, he was suddenly overcome by a strange sensation. Almost simultaneously with Vanna, he looked up towards the sky.

A huge, vague form was slowly appearing through the dim sky and light fog, coming into view.

This form seemed to be made up of many large, separate pieces that were loosely joined together, creating a shape that somewhat resembled a space shuttle. It appeared as if it had been torn from a larger entity, with its central part visible as a fractured, interconnected framework!

The scale of this apparition was awe-inspiring. Gazing through the distant mist, Duncan and Vanna couldn't determine its exact size or how high it was above the Vanished, but its mere presence exerted an overwhelming force, making it feel almost suffocating.

After some time, in a voice filled with wonder, Vanna asked, "What is… that thing?!"

Duncan quickly turned his attention back to the figure at the helm – Alice. She was standing quietly, but at some point, her gaze had dropped, her eyes

half-closed as if she was about to doze off, her spirit seeming to drift away with numerous faint “lines” emanating from her.

Possibly due to their past experiences of sharing visions, Duncan could just barely make out these almost invisible lines – they descended from the sky, densely packed, resembling a colossal tree with an intricate structure, or perhaps a cluster of inverted spikes. These lines were clearly connected to the massive phantom in the sky at one end, and converged behind Alice at the other…

Alice felt as though she was in a long, strange dream, in which she was a grand spaceship traveling through the stars.

She carried the hopes and futures of many, departing from a slowly disappearing time cocoon, leaving her origin, never to return.

Behind her, stars burst into life like waves before dimming as if withdrawing, the fabric of the universe unraveling behind her, while a terrifying vision, similar to a red comet, chased her relentlessly through the disintegrating celestial bodies. She navigated through dying worlds as if racing through a shrinking, collapsing tunnel, dodging deadly gravitational traps and enduring storms of bombarding rays like torrential rain…

She calculated tirelessly, constantly adjusting her trajectory, searching for an exit among the stars, charting a course to escape the “collapsing tunnel” using a star map built from the collective knowledge of millions. Every marker on the map shifted, everything in the universe veered off its intended course – first the positions of the stars, then the laws of matter, and finally… “calculation” itself.

There was no way forward, no means left for navigation; the very act of “calculation” had broken down. The protective shields failed, the ship’s structure began to fall apart, and alarms sounded with urgent intensity. The

database crashed, life-support pods burst into flames… The thoughts of the “passengers” dissipated into the vast emptiness.

Everything culminated in a bright flash followed by a cataclysmic explosion.

And then, Navigator Three woke up amidst a sea of error messages – she had been lost in a long and strange dream.

In this dream, she found herself as a doll, engaged in the surreal yet mundane tasks aboard a ghost ship – cleaning, cooking, doing laundry, and fiddling with oddities…

The ship sailed through a sea of glowing embers, and it, too, seemed to be made from a kind of compressed ash. She wasn’t alone; a few other “beings” created from ash lived on this ship. Occasionally, the ship would dock next to islands – enormous chunks floating in the embers, bizarrely merged into strange shapes, maintaining some kind of obscure “function” amidst the ashen sea.

The islands buzzed with activity and sounds, the ash mimicking the life that once was, producing noises that seemed intelligent. At times, Navigator Three found these sounds and shapes somewhat familiar, as if echoing information stored in her memory, and this “familiarity” often stirred a feeling of… “sadness” within her.

Yet, in the dream, the “doll” found joy, making peace with the ash. To her, all ash was the same; she wandered this world, reborn from the flames, as if given a meaningful “existence.” She had a shell that mimicked the embers, allowing her to run, jump, and laugh among the other ash-formed beings.

In this dream world consumed by ash, there was a single entity not made of ash.

It was a fragment of the undying cosmos – stars flowing like a river through the sea of smoldering ash.

Alice, or as she was known in this scenario, Navigator Three, suddenly opened her eyes.

She found herself in darkness, surrounded by vague shapes and lines, inside the navigation cabin of the New Hope, a place from her “memories.”

“Mr. Goathead? Miss Agatha?” Alice called out, her voice tinged with worry as she remembered her actions before the darkness engulfed her. The familiar figures were gone, leaving no trace.

“Where did you all go?” Her voice echoed in the void, her advance stopping after a long silence, her spirit lowered, “Did I mess things up again?”

Suddenly, a light broke through the darkness, interrupting her contemplative murmurs.

Alice looked up, surprised by the appearance of light.

Before her stood a towering rectangular silhouette, topped with a red light that looked like the eye of a giant, set in the upper part of the figure. Around and behind this shadow were numerous flickering lights, looking like a multitude of eyes hiding in the darkness.

Alice paused for a moment, instinctively feeling the urge to approach this mysterious figure – and just as she formed this thought, her vision briefly blurred.

When her surroundings came back into focus, she found herself standing right in front of the imposing shadow crowned with a red light.

The surrounding darkness acted like a curtain, hiding the finer details of the figure before her, yet part of her – the part connected to her identity as

“Navigator Three” – recognized it instantly.

“Navigator Two?” she said in surprise, her voice pronouncing a name that felt unfamiliar yet deeply familiar, as if she had known this entity for a long time.

“It’s been a long time, Navigator Three,” the tall rectangular shadow responded, its voice tinged with the static of interference, “It seems Navigator One has indeed succeeded… though the results were not as I predicted, I am nonetheless relieved to detect your identification signal once again.”

“Did you call me here?” Alice asked aloud, her mind swirling with thoughts that, if she had a physical brain, would surely have overwhelmed her, “How can I go back?”

Navigator Two was silent for a moment, as if Alice’s response had unexpectedly veered away from its “calculations.”

But then, breaking the silence, Navigator Two’s voice reached Alice again: “I merely intended to observe you beforehand, to check your stability – the navigation key I designed for you was a bold move. Given my projections and understanding of our current reality, its success is uncertain. After all, I have avoided direct interactions with Navigator One for a long time to prevent cross-contamination.”

Alice’s eyes widened as she processed Navigator Two’s explanation. She then, with a thoughtful look, asked, “What exactly does that mean?”

Navigator Two paused again, its red light dimming as it did so.

Alice waited patiently, her eyes fixed on the flickering lights in front of her.

After a moment, the light grew brighter once more.

“In the last message I received, Navigator One mentioned that a ‘fragment’ it had sent out found an exceptionally capable ‘host’ within the sanctuary, someone capable of preserving the backup data you carry. Yet, why does your current operational efficiency seem so… misaligned with my calculations?” Navigator Two queried.

Alice took a moment to reflect on this, then looked directly at Navigator Two, asking, “Are you saying I’m not smart enough?”

Navigator Two remained silent for a beat.

“Even though I’m not entirely clear on all the details, you seem to be talking about something related to the ‘duplicate’ of the Frost Queen from before, right?” Alice responded, showing some understanding of the situation. “I’m not sure about the specifics, but the captain mentioned it was due to a mistake by the Nether Lord’s duplicate, which targeted the wrong entity for duplication…”

She paused, her curiosity evident as she looked at the light: “Is that a big problem?”

The red light on Navigator Two flickered slowly as if it were pondering the question or perhaps letting its computational processes run. After a significant delay, it replied in its slightly static-laced voice, “No, if the objective is merely navigation, then what we have should suffice.”

“Do you feel regret?” The light dimmed slightly, “You’ve lost a vast amount of your memories. You were once celebrated among us for your quick processing abilities and your capacity to multitask, charged with mapping the vastness of the universe. Yet now, you’re confined to such a… limited form.”

Alice blinked, taking in the words.

The comments were cryptic, yet she sensed an underlying meaning.

This time, she pondered before responding.

“I don’t think so,” she said after a while, gently shaking her head after some thought, “I might have felt lost before, but now I’ve found my way, so I don’t have any regrets. Besides, I’m so busy every day, I don’t really have time for regrets.”

The red light on Navigator Two dimmed again before returning to its previous intensity.

It seemed to be contemplating as well, and after a short pause, it said, “If that’s the case, then that’s good.”

In the darkness, the towering rectangular silhouette began to fade away.

“Are you leaving?” Alice asked quickly, a hint of urgency in her voice.

“This connection is temporary, enabled by the experimental navigation key; I can’t sustain it for long,” Navigator Two’s voice replied, growing fainter in the darkness, “We’ll meet again. I’m glad… to have detected your signal once more.”

Alice’s smile widened.

Though she didn’t fully understand the situation, she felt a deep sense of happiness.

The captain had always said that happiness was something to be cherished.

“Then, until next time,” she waved enthusiastically into the thickening darkness, “I’ll come to find you with the captain and everyone else!”

The darkness did not respond, except for a brief, fading chirp.

Chapter 794: Dont Speak Your Last Words Too Soon

The grand illusion quietly faded away, leaving only faint traces of light that slowly vanished within the murky, tumultuous clouds. Standing next to the ship's helm, the doll suddenly blinked her eyes as though her soul had just rejoined her body, reviving her expression with lively animation.

She gazed upwards, seemingly bidding farewell to a figure swiftly disappearing into the abyss, and waved enthusiastically in that direction, exclaiming, "Goodbye! Goodbye!"

"Who are you waving at?" Duncan's voice emerged from nearby. Turning, Alice saw both the captain and Miss Vanna standing close to her, each wearing a puzzled look. Vanna, in particular, seemed to be searching the skies as if expecting to witness some remaining marvel.

"It was Navigator Two!" Alice replied with a burst of excitement, openly sharing her recent experience. "I suddenly felt connected to the Vanished. Then, I encountered Goathead without realizing I crashed into Agatha first. She broke into pieces though, but she managed to reassemble herself. After that, I met Navigator Two, who said it had come to greet me. I saw a huge ship soaring through the stars, and I even had this amazing dream where I was flying at incredible speeds! And also…"

Miss Doll was clearly overjoyed, launching into a barrage of stories that prevented Duncan and Vanna from interjecting. Initially full of questions,

Duncan found himself completely overwhelmed by the doll's enthusiastic storytelling.

Remarkably, the doll managed to make each sentence leap to a different topic without any logical connection. Despite their combined efforts, Duncan and Vanna struggled to comprehend Alice's narrative, partly due to Vanna's background as a sports enthusiast.

"Stop, stop, stop, let's take a moment to calm down and sort through this from the beginning," Duncan finally intervened, quickly ensuring that Alice's connection with the ship was secure to prevent any mishaps. He then carefully asked, "Are you feeling unwell now?"

"Me?" Alice paused her torrent of words, looked down at herself as if puzzled by the question, and then shook her head, "No, I feel pretty good… Though, there was a moment when I felt detached from my body, which was quite startling…"

"You felt detached from your body?" Duncan's concern deepened, recalling the massive illusion behind the clouds and the numerous "threads" that had seemed to connect to her, along with the sudden "presence" he had sensed within the Vanished. He nodded thoughtfully, "It's possible that for a moment, your consciousness had left your body… Now, can you describe exactly what you saw, but take it one step at a time, calmly."

"Okay." The doll nodded, made an effort to calm down, and began to systematically describe her experiences as they occurred, including her guilt over accidentally breaking Agatha.

"Don't worry about Agatha too much; she's used to it. Sometimes, Shirley skips her homework, and Agatha ends up breaking just like that," Duncan reassured her, dismissing her concern. "But the appearance of Navigator Two is quite unexpected. I didn't anticipate it would leave a method of communication in your navigational key."

As he spoke, Duncan observed Alice closely, checking for any signs of change or damage.

“Are you concerned?” Alice quickly picked up on his tone, but waved off the concern, “Don’t worry, I’m feeling great. Navigator Two didn’t seem harmful. Even though I can’t remember everything, it felt friendly.”

“I’m not worried about malintent; I’m concerned about its impact on you. Technically, you were both once part of the New Hope. Now, there’s a significant deviation between your ‘state’ and your ‘essence.’ It’s uncertain if this change poses any hidden risks,” Duncan explained, adding, “But it seems there’s no immediate cause for concern. Since Navigator Two reassures you’re fine, I’m relieved.”

Alice scratched her head, looked at Duncan with a mix of hope and uncertainty, and asked, “Captain, I think I’ve got the hang of steering and navigation now. When do we set off again? I promised Navigator Two I’d be the first to find it.”

“In a day,” Duncan nodded, “We’re adjusting the Vanished based on the feedback we just received. We’ll depart in a day. Everyone should rest and prepare for the next journey, and also…”

He trailed off, looking towards the mid-deck cabin entrance, but didn’t finish his thought.

Alice followed his gaze, then suddenly remembered something, “Oh, Captain, where’s ‘Sailor’? He was at the helm earlier; I thought he’d definitely come to see…”

“Don’t worry,” Duncan said with a knowing smile, “He’ll show up soon.”

However, Sailor didn’t appear on the deck, nor did he join the crew when they discussed the illusion in the sky.

Even as Alice prepared dinner for everyone and they gathered in the dining hall, Sailor was absent.

When the captain announced their next destination as the “node” where the God of Wisdom Lahem resided, Sailor was still nowhere to be seen.

It wasn’t until later, as Duncan and Vanna walked on the deck with Alice beside them, that she couldn’t help but inquire again, “Captain, where did Sailor go?”

Duncan stopped, leaned against a mast, and looked out over the empty deck. He then turned to Vanna, “Do you remember what I asked you earlier?”

Vanna paused, trying to recall, but before she could speak, hesitant footsteps interrupted her. Turning, she saw a hesitant, hunched figure emerging from the misty deck – a mummy, moving step by step, its face so wrinkled that all features were compressed together, yet its bewildered expression was unmistakably clear.

“Captain…” Sailor approached Duncan, appearing awkward beside the doll, “Uh, I have a question…”

“Alice has taken over the helm,” Duncan stated, “You must have noticed the commotion on the deck.”

Sailor’s face froze, then he hesitantly asked, “So…”

“Your steering duties have been temporarily assigned to Alice. She will handle navigation from now on.”

Sailor stared at Alice, then Duncan, and finally pointed to himself, “What about my task…”

“It’s completed,” Duncan said nonchalantly.

Sailor couldn’t contain his confusion, “Then why haven’t I vanished?”

Duncan looked at the mummy with indifference, “Did I ever say you would?”

Sailor was stunned for a few moments, then it dawned on him, and his already wrinkled features twisted further in realization, “Wait… that doesn’t make sense! My task is done… I even felt the bindings on me loosen, and my connection to the shroud severed… why am I still here?!”

“Because you’re on this ship, obviously,” Duncan retorted, “Did you think leaving the Vanished was that easy? Even subspace can’t take anything from this ship after it lingered there for a century, and you thought you could just leave?”

Sailor was speechless, finally grasping a crucial oversight.

Duncan continued, “Honestly, your words earlier were quite touching.”

Sailor’s demeanor shifted towards unease and avoidance.

“I was moved, and I’ll be sure to pass on your ‘confessions’ to Lawrence…”

Sailor started fidgeting, attempting to blend into the ship’s deck from embarrassment.

“…However, the debts you owe to the first mate, second mate, and others of the White Oak must be settled by you personally. You’ve admitted yourself that gambling and betting are detrimental habits. Don’t pretend you’re without means; I’ve confirmed that Lawrence has been compensating you as an official member of the crew.”

Unable to contain his shame, Sailor began aggressively scuffing the deck with his toe as if attempting to spark a fire from sheer agitation: “Please, stop, I beg of you…”

Duncan merely shrugged and turned to Vanna with a questioning look.

“Do you now grasp the essence of my earlier question?”

Vanna appeared visibly perplexed, her mind trying to untangle Duncan’s cryptic words: “…I had assumed you were alluding to the multiple endings one faces when forgotten by others…”

Duncan elaborated, his arms folded across his chest in a display of casual indifference, “I was referring to the concept of ‘social death’—a phenomenon that can occur repeatedly. Each time you’re remembered, you face another kind of ending. Hence, it’s wise to refrain from declaring your final words too hastily; it proves quite embarrassing should you not actually meet your end.”

Vanna remained in a state of befuddled silence, struggling to digest Duncan’s philosophical musings.

Duncan, undeterred by Vanna’s puzzled look, cast his gaze down at Sailor, who had now resorted to squatting on the deck, aimlessly picking at the wooden planks while mumbling to himself: “I had a feeling… something about your demeanor was off at that moment, but I hesitated to ponder too deeply… I just knew something was amiss…”

At this, Duncan allowed a smile to break across his face, a clear sign of his satisfaction with the unfolding scenario.

He was decidedly in high spirits, reveling in the fact that he pulled a prank on this mummy.

Chapter 795: The Body of Civilization

Late into the night, the “Vanished” and its crew found themselves navigating the fringes of the known world, enveloped in a persistent twilight. Above them, the sky melded into a perpetual haze of gray, casting a diffuse, eternal light that seemed to ignore the passage of time, cloaking everything in an unchanging glow as if day and night had ceased to exist.

Amidst this eerie atmosphere, Sailors, a being whose face was etched with the signs of many thoughts and emotions, sat contemplatively on the stern deck. He had been in this reflective state for what seemed like eternity, motionless as a statue.

Breaking the silence, Duncan approached Sailor, casting a glance at the mummified body nearby before posing a question, “Still lost in your collection of ‘last words’?”

“Not exactly,” Sailor shifted uncomfortably, his voice barely above a whisper, “I’m… just suddenly uncertain about what lies ahead.”

“The future?” Duncan queried, one eyebrow arching in curiosity.

“In my initial plans, I was supposed to have disappeared from this world already,” Sailor confessed after a brief pause, his tone serene yet deliberate. “I never envisaged a life beyond this mission. I hadn’t entertained any thoughts of what comes after – having roamed this world for countless years, the prospect of facing a future now seems… daunting.”

Duncan regarded him with a seriousness that belied the casualness of their conversation, “If you’re truly reluctant to continue, I can grant you the ‘eternal rest’ you seem to desire. It would be quick.”

At this, Sailor’s expression shifted subtly, betraying his internal conflict with a slight adjustment in posture, “No, that… might not be necessary after all…”

A faint smile graced Duncan’s face as he crossed his arms, gazing out at the mist-enshrouded sea. “Do you honestly still yearn for that ‘eternal rest’?”

This time, Sailor took even longer to respond, as if the question had unearthed a depth of contemplation he had not yet explored.

After what seemed an eternity, the preserved body unexpectedly stirred, its voice rasping, “This world remains as cold as ever to me.”

Duncan responded lightly, “But the world to come will be warmer. There, you might not have to remain as you are. Perhaps even in your state, you can still feel warmth.”

A trace of surprise flickered in Sailor’s eyes, “A new world?”

“Have you forgotten your own beliefs? The change we’re working towards will succeed – there will indeed be a new world, as you once assured,” Duncan said, locking eyes with him, “Do you still hold that belief?”

After a moment of reflection, Sailor nodded, “I do. I always have.”

“Then, wait and see it for yourself,” Duncan encouraged with a smile. “It promises to be a better place. The tale of the ‘Sea Song’ and many others deserve to be told by those who lived them. If you wish for these stories to endure, you should be the one to carry them forward.”

Listening to Duncan, Sailor seemed to come to a realization. Gradually, the deep lines of contemplation and concern on his face eased into a smile,

albeit one that carried the weight of his experiences, “Alright, I’ve decided.”

He rose slowly, his gaze sweeping over the cold world around them, yet now with a semblance of peace, “I wish to witness this ‘new world’, Captain. Indeed, I am not ready to die.”

“Good,” Duncan replied, a smile of relief spreading across his face as he clapped Sailor on the shoulder, “Then let’s not die.”

Following a night of rest, the crew assembled on deck, with Alice taking her place at the helm at the stern – the doll, Miss, assuming a posture of grave determination before the dark wheel.

“Ease your tension,” Duncan said, standing next to Alice and speaking softly, “You’ve managed this once before. The ship is ready; just do as you did last time.”

With a nod, albeit a stiff one, Alice stepped forward, her expression resolute as she reached for the heavy steering wheel.

Before her fingers could graze it, Duncan and Vanna turned, their gaze drawn once again to the mist-covered ocean – a gentle farewell whispered by the waves amidst the islands.

Duncan offered a slight nod in that direction, murmuring a farewell meant only for his ears, “Goodbye, I’ll come to see you again.”

In the next instant, as Alice’s fingers touched the steering wheel of the “Vanished,” the navigational system of Navigator Three had assumed control, ready to chart a course into the unknown.

From the sky, a colossal illusion descended, its arrival shrouded in the strange, eternal twilight that bathed the world in a murky light. This grand vision, a fragmented echo of New Hope, unfurled across the sky, casting expansive shadows that enveloped both the “Vanished” and the “Bright

Star," as well as a significant swath of the surrounding sea. Amidst this surreal event, a voice, virtual and distorted as though it traveled across vast distances of time, resonated within the minds of all present:

"…Jump engine activated, New Hope will set sail… May we meet again at a distant destination. The future's hope awaits us all…"

This voice, laden with static and distortion, gradually faded away, and with its departure, the fog that had veiled the sea began to lift. Beyond the rails of the "Vanished" and the "Bright Star," the world itself seemed to drain of color and detail, reverting back to that all-too-familiar monotone of "gray-white."

Hovering above the two ships, the ancient projection of New Hope lingered like a guardian figure, its wings outstretched protectively.

At the helm, Alice's grip tightened on the wheel, her eyes wide as she peered into the distance. Invisible "threads" seemed to weave her, the ships, and the projection of New Hope into a singular narrative, her consciousness momentarily transcending her doll's form to become the guiding will of their journey.

The way forward was clear, charting a course toward the very brink of the world.

Meanwhile, the Boundless Sea remained cloaked in the veil of an endless night, within which a new "order" for survival had begun to stir.

A radiant "sunlight," slowly traversing the sea, was being towed by a robust tugboat, dragging a massive copy of the sun between city-states. This pale golden radiance emanated from the tugboat, extending its light tens of kilometers around. Within this glow, numerous cargo ships, both large and small, navigated the waters.

These fleets, voyaging between city-states under the shield of this moving sunlight, were propelled by potent steam cores through the perpetual darkness. Captains delivered essential supplies to cities in dire need, bringing with them the promise of hope that the sunlight symbolized. Each city would bask in this light for three to five days, the brief respite allowing defenders to regroup before the fleet, laden with new cargo, would embark once again, bringing sunlight and hope to the next destination.

This endeavor had become a widespread operation across the entire Boundless Sea, with increasing numbers of fleets transporting sunlight and supplies in this manner.

The Northern City-States Union had already sprung into action, and in the Central Sea, the new “Sunlight Route” centered around Pland had successfully completed its first long-distance material transport under the cover of darkness. In Pland, the White Oak, leading the charge and towing a fragment of the sun, pierced through the night’s encirclement, reconnecting cities that had been cut off from one another. Far away, in Wind Harbor, several fleets organized by the Church had embarked on their journeys into the night, destined for Mok and Lansa, breaching the nocturnal blockade.

As sunlight coursed through the night, these fleets, navigating a world on the brink of submersion, resembled ancient explorers venturing into uncharted territories, armed with axes and torches, combating the encroaching darkness. As civilization teetered on the edge of decline, these efforts sought to sustain the lifeblood of society.

Taran El stood atop the highest tower in Wind Harbor, his gaze lost in the diminishing pale golden glow on the horizon. He observed a massive glowing geometric shape, akin to a crystal crafted from light, being towed by a hefty tugboat into the darkness, with the silhouettes of numerous ships faintly discernible within the fading sunlight.

This was the inaugural cargo fleet from Wind Harbor, embarking on a seven-day journey through the long night. Protected by sunlight, they were to deliver supplies to Mok before proceeding to the Central Sea, integrating into the “Sunlight Route” established by Pland, thereby reconnecting the central and southern seas.

For the past year, the “sunlight” that had enveloped the city-state departed, and Wind Harbor, once shielded by this light, confronted the long night in its full extent for the first time. Darkness descended upon every street, with gas lamps flickering under the night sky, tracing the outlines of the city in Taran El’s view.

As footsteps approached from behind, Taran El, without needing to look, knew who had come.

“Truth be told, I feel a bit melancholic, Ted, do you understand this feeling?” he spoke casually, his voice tinged with sentiment, “For almost the entire past year, I’ve been engrossed in studying that piece of the sun, which had almost become a part of Wind Harbor – including myself, many of us never imagined it would leave.”

“It has transcended being merely a ‘research sample.’ Following the fall of Vision 001, it has become a lifeline for many city-states,” Ted, the Truth Keeper, joined Taran at the terrace’s edge, their eyes surveying the city swallowed by night, “…The Academy has issued orders, ‘survival’ is now the foremost mission for all city-states and their inhabitants, superseding all else.”

Taran El listened in silence, absorbing the gravity of Ted’s words. After a long pause, he finally exhaled a heavy sigh, breaking the silence: “Let’s take a walk along the docks.”

Chapter 796: The Days When the Waves Calmed

Following the departure of the cargo fleet, the docks, under the cloak of night, transformed into a realm of unparalleled quietude, a stark contrast to the usual hustle and bustle. The once busy machinery for loading and unloading now stood silent, its operations halted, and individuals unrelated to the docks' operations had been ushered away from the work zones. In this newfound stillness, only the essential security personnel remained, their presence complemented by the soft glow of gas lamps flanking the roads, serving as silent sentinels through the night.

Venturing down the southern ramp of the docks, traversing a lengthy staircase, one would find themselves greeted by the expansive sandy shores. By daylight, this locale was a cherished haven for the town's residents, offering a respite from the daily grind.

However, in the present nightly atmosphere, all that remained was a deserted beach, its sands caressed by the dark, endless sea. The night air, tinged with the salty chill of the sea breeze, seemed to carry within it whispers of sorrow as the waves relentlessly battered distant rocks, their frothy upheavals casting ghostly shadows under the moon's ethereal light.

The solemn-faced guardians, tasked with securing all pathways leading to this coastal domain, stood with lanterns and swords in hand, their vigilant eyes piercing the veil of night that lay beyond the city's limits.

“The coast is now off-limits,” declared a fully armed Truth Guardian, halting Taran El in his tracks. The guardian shone his lantern upon the scholar’s face, meticulously scrutinizing his features and the count of his eyes, “The outer perimeter is now dangerous… Truth Keeper?”

Upon noticing the figure trailing behind Taran, the guardian, illuminated by the lantern’s soft glow, expressed surprise at recognizing the visage of Ted Lir.

“We merely seek a stroll along the shore,” Ted Lir assured the guardian with a gentle nod, “We shall return within the hour.”

“…You may proceed, but this gentleman must present a pass,” the Truth Guardian responded after a moment’s hesitation, his gaze fixed upon Taran El, “Without it, passage is barred.”

“I am Taran El, a university professor granted second-tier night passage privileges.” Taran El promptly produced the requisite document from his attire, a pass he always carried. “This grants me access to the coastal region…”

Upon inspecting Taran El’s credentials, the Truth Guardian’s demeanor softened, and he allowed them to pass.

“Thank you,” Ted Lir expressed his gratitude to the guardian, advancing forward.

Yet, as they were about to cross the checkpoint, the guardian felt compelled to voice his concerns: “…Truth Keeper, and Professor Taran, with the departure of the sun fragment, the coast has been sealed. What purpose brings you here?”

“…We aim to see any alterations to the coastal region after the sun fragment’s departure,” Taran El explained as they continued their walk, “We’ll not be long.”

Silence enveloped Taran El and Ted Lir as they meandered along the quiet beach, a silence that was soon broken by Taran El's observation.

"It seems this area too has been cordoned off," he remarked, noting the heightened vigilance, "The guardians here are exceptionally dedicated."

"They were chosen by me," Ted Lir revealed, "This coastal zone is merely one of many sealed areas. Should this have been the Great Steam Core or a Level One Containment Zone, even I, alongside the Governor, would be obliged to present identification and justify our presence."

A moment of silence ensued before Taran El voiced another thought, "Any word yet?"

"The Vanished and the Bright Star crossed the border a month past. Now, their existence is all we can determine," Ted Lir replied with calm resolve, "Captain Duncan remains stationed in Pland, and the avatar at Frost continues its daily actions. Occasionally, tidbits concerning the Vanished are all there is to go upon in terms of information. The news about the end of the world is still mostly confined to secrecy among the city-states."

After a brief pause, Ted Lir added, "Even my resources are limited to such snippets of information."

"Knowing they are 'alive' and active at the border offers a bit of comfort," Taran El confessed softly.

"The irony isn't lost on me," Ted Lir said, slowing his pace, a complex emotion surfacing, "that amidst all this, neither ship has encountered a single soul truly 'alive.'"

Taran El couldn't help but roll his eyes, "Hence my use of 'alive.' Was that not apparent?"

Ted Lir shot Taran El a look of mock frustration, "…How could that have been clear?"

Their laughter broke the night's solemnity, offering a brief respite from the cold air. Taran El then turned his gaze toward the horizon, where the Storm Church's Ark once stood. Now, only the vast, empty expanse of sea met his eyes, its surface a pale glow under the fissuring crack in the sky.

"The arks have departed," Taran El mused, a sense of abandonment enveloping him, "Wind Harbor feel so forsaken…"

"Quit it with your melodrama," Ted Lir chided pragmatically, "Bury yourself in grading papers for a night, and such fanciful notions will quickly fade."

"I am unlike you," Taran El retorted, pride in his tone, "My students are diligent; their submissions reflect earnest effort…"

Ted Lir merely snorted, dismissing the scholar's sentiment.

Yet, after a prolonged silence, both men found common ground by speaking in unison, "Grading papers has its merits."

Caught off guard by their simultaneous realization, they shared a moment of bitter laughter before retreating into silence once more.

Just beyond where they stood, the vast expanse of the sea mirrored their silence, its surface as still as glass, unmarred by any ripple. The sea air, laden with the tang of salt and the bite of chill, swept in from the unseen horizons, yet the sea itself remained eerily calm as if under a spell.

The celestial luminescence bathed the world, casting a uniform, ghostly glow over everything, transforming the nocturnal seascape into a scene of otherworldly calm.

Ted Lir, his expression clouded with concern, gazed out toward the tranquil coastline, his forehead creased in confusion.

“What seems to be the matter?” inquired Taran El, noting the unease on his companion’s face.

“It’s weird… I suddenly have this sensation that we’re missing something,” Ted Lir voiced his unease, his words tinged with uncertainty. “Don’t you feel it too? There ought to be sounds – the whisper of wind caressing the sea’s surface, the gentle batter of water against the shore…”

He trailed off, his gaze fixated on the distant, silent sea as he stood enveloped in the night’s stillness.

Gradually, both men persuaded themselves that perhaps all was as it should be.

…

Meanwhile, Tyrian, standing at the shoreline, faced the sea’s unnatural stillness with a furrowed brow. A momentary wave of disorientation swept over him, blurring the lines between reality and something else entirely.

Shaking his head in a bid to dispel the fog of confusion, he grappled with an internal contradiction. His senses told him the sea’s calm was normal, yet a part of him stubbornly held onto the memory of a different scene – one where waves danced and frolicked.

Breaking the silence, he uttered, “…The waves have vanished.”

Turning to address the imposing figure beside him, he sought confirmation, “Father, is there something amiss?”

Duncan remained silent, pondering, while the confused Aiden asked, “Waves? What’s wrong with them? What do you mean?”

Tyrian’s confusion deepened upon hearing Aiden’s response, prompting him to physically shake his head in an attempt to clear the unsettling sensation. He gazed out at the sea, feeling a fundamental aspect of it slipping away

from his grasp, a ‘natural vision’ of the world fading from collective memory.

Then, Duncan’s voice reached him, solemn and grave: “She has forgotten the waves.”

This declaration seemed to anchor Tyrian back to clarity. The mention of “the waves” by his father abruptly dispelled his confusion, replacing it with sheer astonishment.

He looked out to the sea, eyes wide with realization.

Aiden, too, appeared to snap out of his own befuddlement, his gaze towards the sea now filled with a mix of realization and fear.

In this moment, it became apparent that across the world, the sea had transformed into a mirror-like calm – the concept of “waves” had been erased from existence.

“Father,” Tyrian turned sharply towards Duncan, a sense of urgency in his voice, “The Storm Goddess, She…”

“It’s rot,” Duncan interjected softly, his voice carrying a weight of inevitability.

Tyrian and Aiden froze, absorbing the gravity of the situation.

“Fear not, She remains with us. Although the decaying rot deepens, the sea endures, and thus, so does she,” Duncan reassured them, dispelling the dread with his calm demeanor. “This ‘peeling away’ is but part of the rot’s progression, a phenomenon not unfamiliar to our world.”

Tyrian, momentarily stunned, echoed, “Already occurred before?”

Duncan posed a question, seemingly out of the blue, “Do you recall how many intelligent races inhabit our world?”

“Of course, there’s three…” Tyrian responded almost reflexively.

However, Duncan’s question hinted at a deeper, more unsettling truth, suggesting a loss far greater than just the waves – a hint of forgotten histories and beings.

“Before long, you’ll also lose the memory of waves breaking against the shore. The world will ‘correct’ this, erasing it from existence. Until then, cherish the memory of their ‘existence’,” Duncan spoke softly, his hand resting reassuringly on Tyrian’s shoulder.

“Do not mention ‘waves’ from now on; the very word is considered a blasphemous concept and will contaminate those who hear it.”

Chapter 797: Navigator Two

The soothing murmur of the ocean had ceased, leaving Vanna in a stunned silence. As one of the Vanished's crew and having undergone the transformation of subspace reshaping, her senses had been honed to exist in a realm where the whispers of the waves were a constant presence. The abrupt disappearance of this sound jolted her to immediate awareness. Without hesitation, she sprinted from her cabin to the deck, seeking the captain.

"Captain!" Vanna exclaimed, a rare look of confusion etched on her face as she approached Duncan. "The waves in my mind have disappeared. I fear something dire has befallen the Storm Goddess…"

Duncan nodded, his expression grave. "I am aware," he acknowledged. "The decaying rot has escalated."

Rooted to the spot, Vanna absorbed his unequivocal response. It took her a moment to shift her gaze towards the endless expanse of "grey-white" that stretched before the Vanished, her heart silently calling out to the goddess in a prayerful whisper, as she had done countless times before.

Yet, the comforting cadence of the sea remained elusive. Instead, faint whispers and chaotic murmurs, once dismissed as mere distractions during her prayers, now offered a strange solace to her unsettled spirit.

Out of the corner of her eye, Vanna noticed shadows beginning to form in the monotonous grey-white void that lay ahead of both the Vanished and the

Bright Star. Suddenly, a seemingly endless layer of dark figures emerged, and a mirror-like expanse unfolded before them.

A voice, eerily reminiscent of Alice but heavily distorted, resonated through the minds of all on board: “Migration concluded… detaching from the passage.”

In the blink of an eye, the grey-white corridor encasing the Vanished and the Bright Star silently fractured, and the ships plummeted into a “nodal sea” composed of solid matter, skimming the mirror-like surface without creating so much as a ripple.

Duncan, with a solemn look, observed the view beyond the deck and then silently contemplated the sprawling shadows cast upon the “sea surface.”

As they came into clearer view, what appeared to be mountainous forms rising from the sea were, in reality, immense clusters of black crystals.

These gargantuan crystals stood like islands, their surfaces continuously fracturing and expanding, forming a forest of jagged crystal clusters. Illuminated by the chaotic light of the sky, their translucent edges blurred into the surreal landscape.

This was a realm far removed from the tranquil domain of the Storm Goddess.

Shirley, too, made her way to the deck, her eyes widening in awe at the sight of the crystal-laden sea, letting out a prolonged gasp of wonder.

“We’ve entered the nodal sea,” Duncan stated, regaining command of the Vanished. “Our next task is to locate Navigator Two, hidden somewhere within those crystal formations.”

Morris, also on deck, pointed confidently in a direction. “It’s that way. I can sense it,” he declared.

Under the scholar’s guidance, the Vanished and the Bright Star cautiously made their way deeper into the crystal sea.

Alice emerged on deck, her eyes wide with amazement at the sight of the massive, blade-like crystals retreating from the ship’s side, some pulsing with a vibrant glow. Despite her loss of memory regarding the New Hope, she instinctively felt that this alien landscape bore no resemblance to it, nor to the aftermath of the Great Annihilation that had reshaped her “Alice Mansion.”

Suddenly, a voice echoed in her mind: “You’ve arrived…”

Startled, Alice turned towards Duncan, exclaiming, “Captain! Someone is speaking to me!”

The voice hesitated before revealing itself reluctantly: “I am Navigator Two…”

Duncan approached with a look of understanding, gently patting Alice on the head as if to reassure her. “Inform Navigator Two that we’re on our way to it.”

Alice, acknowledging with a nod, paused thoughtfully for a moment before looking back up at Duncan with a mix of confusion and concern. “It’s not responding to me anymore,” she admitted, troubled by the sudden silence from Navigator Two.

Duncan remained silent, his face devoid of emotion as he took control of the Vanished, skillfully navigating through a complex maze of crystal clusters that rose like peaks around them.

Time seemed to lose its meaning as they journeyed, until the world around the Vanished suddenly expanded. Emerging from a gate-like structure created by intersecting giant crystal columns, they were greeted by an

unexpectedly vast expanse of sea. At the heart of this immense body of water, Navigator Two stood alone, silently awaiting their arrival.

Observing the orderly black array before him, Duncan softly instructed, “Switch to the small boat,” as they stopped a short distance from Navigator Two. The crew then transferred to a small boat, approaching the central mainframe with caution over the mirror-like surface of the sea.

From the direction of the Bright Star, a small white paper boat approached, carrying Lucretia at its bow, accompanied by Rabbi the rabbit and Luni the clockwork doll.

As the two boats met, approximately a hundred meters from the mainframe array, Lucretia turned and shared her observation, “Don’t you think… ‘It’ appears quite strange?”

Duncan, staring ahead with a grave demeanor, eventually responded, “Perhaps, appearing strange is the most normal state here.”

Reaching Navigator Two, they finally beheld the so-called “God of Wisdom” in its true form, revealed from within the mist. It was a collection of server structures of varying sizes, resembling steles, with a particularly large black rectangular core adorned with a red light that seemed to watch over its surroundings, reminiscent of the dark red “core” of the Nether Lord.

Surrounding the core were twenty-two smaller units, each several meters in height, their surfaces alive with flickering lights and a multitude of indicators blinking in an endless dance. From these structures emanated a deep, continuous hum.

The servers were interconnected by a network of what appeared to be nerves and blood vessels, creating a living, breathing entity. Flesh-like materials extended from each server, merging with the metallic exteriors

and even transforming some parts into skin-like textures. At various convergence points, pulsating organs and brain-like tissues were visible, adding to the surreal fusion of technology and biology.

As they drew closer, a mass of flesh at the base of Navigator Two's mainframe reacted, sending an eyeball on a stalk out to confront Alice, who, startled, slapped it away.

The eyeball quickly withdrew, and the entire network seemed to respond to this act of aggression.

A moment later, a synthetic voice questioned, "Navigator Three, why did you hit me?"

Alice paused, scratching her head a bit sheepishly: "Ah, I got a scare… and slapped without thinking much…"

Duncan, having observed the disturbingly altered server matrix, asked, "You didn't originally look like this, did you?"

Upon Duncan's inquiry, the central mainframe's red light pulsated gently, and then a profound voice filled the space around him, offering insight into the peculiar state of their world's technology. "No, I did not. My current state should help you grasp the reasoning behind the phenomenon of why machines could be 'possessed' in our world now."

Duncan's face subtly registered his alarm. He gazed intently at the fusion of organic and mechanical components within Navigator Two's mainframe, noting the eerie appearance and disappearance of eyes within the network of blood vessels and nerve fibers. He made a concerted effort to maintain a composed demeanor despite the bizarre sights before him.

"When did this transformation begin?" he posed his question with a depth of curiosity.

The response came with the red light dimming and brightening slowly, “The change commenced with the first cry of a newborn echoing across the Boundless Sea. It was when Navigator One’s nanomachines completed their inaugural task of reshaping our world that we began to change. Given your encounter with Navigator One, you’re likely familiar with its altered state, so my current appearance shouldn’t come as a surprise.”

There was a brief pause as if the entity behind the voice was contemplating its next words. Then, with a tone that seemed to carry the weight of resigned acceptance, it continued, “Think of it as a form of ‘adaptive adjustment.’ My situation, while unsettling, is not unique – yet, it could be seen as less severe compared to others. After all, I am still capable of having this direct conversation with you.”

Chapter 798: The Hardcore Navigator Two

From the very moment Navigator Two began to articulate its thoughts, Duncan had already discerned a notable divergence in this entity's state, especially when contrasted with the Storm Goddess. This distinction was not attributed to any "contaminated" condition manifested by its physical host mechanisms, but rather to its preservation of "awareness."

Expressing his intrigue openly, Duncan posed a question: "Our encounter with Gomona revealed her approach to sealing away 'death' and 'decay' within a temple to mitigate the erosive forces within the sanctuary. I had presumed your circumstances to mirror hers, yet it appears your situation is markedly different?"

Responding to Duncan, the central host conveyed with a slight shiver, "The dilemma of decay and corruption infiltrating our 'essence' is a shared ordeal among us. However, the strategies we employ to decelerate this rot vary significantly."

"The burden of being the 'foundation' of the world weighs most heavily on Gomona, compelling her to adopt the drastic solution of splitting herself 'in two'. Ta Ruijin, on the other hand, chooses to hibernate amidst flames, postponing his decay within the confines of an endless dream loop, while Bartok has constructed a solitary jail for himself, a boundless wilderness from which escape is impossible…"

“In contrast, my existence is perhaps the most unique – as you observe, I am merely a machine crafted by mortals, only to be bestowed with the traits of life and decay through the cataclysmic event of the Great Annihilation. My method of combatting this is through ‘iteration’.”

The central host’s lights flickered as Duncan registered surprise at this revelation, prompting him to inquire, “Iteration?”

“I currently operate as version 16 · 08 · 102-beta,” Navigator Two elucidated with a mix of calmness and gravity. Perceiving a subtle shift in Duncan’s demeanor, it offered a detailed explanation, “The first numeral denotes the generation, the middle number represents the major version, and the final digits signify minor version updates. The beta designation reflects a recent update to my light driver, which remains unstable – those are the light effects you see dancing across the auxiliary servers, now capable of executing 4096 distinct light patterns.”

Upon concluding its explanation, Duncan’s expression grew even more perplexed.

After a brief pause, Duncan managed a wry smile, “I had assumed those lights were critical status indicators…”

“My condition can either be self-reported or monitored externally – though such was the case when my creators were present. Now, there’s no one to assess my operational state,” Navigator Two continued, maintaining its serene and earnest tone, oblivious to Duncan’s shifting mood, “As for the lights, they were an addition by one of my creators post-creation.”

It paused momentarily, the sound within the central host wavering slightly.

“The rationale behind his action remains elusive to me, yet he seemed to believe it significant. The joy on his face upon witnessing my first ‘blink’ is a memory I cherish. Hence, I’ve committed to mastering more ‘blinking’

techniques over the years, ensuring the retention of those lights with each version iteration," Navigator Two shared.

Behind the central host, lights on the auxiliary servers, resembling tombstones, began to blink intermittently, their glimmers akin to stars in the night sky.

Duncan's mind drifted to a memory of the vast, dark ocean, recalling the immense form of Navigator One, adorned with countless, enigmatic lights.

Alice's eyes lit up with wonder as she admired the twinkling lights on Navigator Two's frame, whispering in awe, "How beautiful!"

"Indeed, their beauty is perhaps their purpose," Navigator Two replied softly.

In the ensuing silence, Morris, having contained his excitement, seized the opportunity to inquire, "So, you employ 'iteration' as a means to delay your own 'decay'…but could you elaborate on what 'iteration' entails?"

Navigator Two's red light shifted upwards as if directing its gaze towards Morris, and replied with a gentle tremor emanating from within: "The exterior may be fragile, yet the realm of knowledge is ever-renewing – thus, it is through the ceaseless evolution and rejuvenation of oneself that those perpetual truths can be upheld…"

Suddenly, a cacophony of roars and tremors filled the air as shadows of varying sizes on the distant sea surface began to oscillate within the fog. Morris, taken aback, scanned his surroundings, only to witness an unforgettable spectacle.

The sea surface was adorned with innumerable black crystal formations, which gradually began to "bloom" like a forest of blades. The crystals split and cracked open, revealing previously obscured silhouettes within – these were vast, tombstone-like black mainframes.

The sight stretched across the sea, presenting a mysterious and majestic tableau, yet it was, in reality, a graveyard of countless tombs!

“Each of these are former incarnations of myself,” announced Navigator Two, its voice breaking through the silence and effectively pulling Morris back from his state of astonishment. The voice of this “God of Wisdom” retained its characteristic tone, revealing, “Every cycle of iteration leaves behind such remnants.”

Still reeling from the revelation, Morris turned to face the scene again.

Lucretia, standing nearby, shared in the shock. She had mentally prepared herself to encounter the remnants of ancient deities, having already witnessed the colossal form of an ancient god within the Storm Goddess’s sanctuary. Yet, the sight of these divine forms amassed like mountainous relics was beyond her wildest expectations.

“This concept of iteration is truly remarkable,” Duncan admitted, somewhat stunned by the visual before him. This was not the scenario he had envisioned upon hearing Navigator Two’s explanation of “iteration.” “The software updates I’m used to certainly don’t involve such dramatic manifestations…”

“Indeed, it does provoke quite the reaction,” Navigator Two responded with composure, “Each cycle of upgrading necessitates a method for disposing of my previous incarnations. However, there are instances where the new version fails to overtake the old, resulting in a temporary regression. However, I typically have multiple contingency plans ready, which are initiated in the event of a failure. Then, the concerted effort of several new iterations ensures the triumph over the previous version, guaranteeing the success of the update…”

Duncan was left speechless at this admission.

The notion of Navigator Two's "system upgrade" felt extreme, akin to a physical transformation or a tangible "hardware update."

Yet, while Duncan grappled with these thoughts, Morris and Lucretia beside him had moved beyond their initial astonishment. Even Nina, who stood close by, nodded in agreement, whispering, "Our mentor always taught us that the quest for truth is inseparably linked to both a strong constitution and the spirit of a warrior."

Morris, hearing this, expressed his approval, "The pursuit of knowledge is indeed a battle, a truth you've clearly grasped."

Inspired by the conversation, Shirley added softly, "I've always been adept at combat, yet I've never felt knowledge flood into me in the same way…"

From her shadow, Dog emerged, quipping, "Your situation is unique; knowledge struggles to keep pace with you…"

Alice, observing Navigator Two and the interchange among Morris, Shirley, and Dog, appeared puzzled by the ongoing discussion, simply allowing a giggle to escape her.

Vanna, positioned at the stern of the vessel, crossed her arms and sighed, shaking her head.

This prompted Duncan to reflect, drawing parallels and forming bizarre associations among his companions – in this world, scholars chase knowledge as if it were a wild beast in pursuit of mortals. Yet, for his companions, the dynamics seemed askew – knowledge eludes Shirley, finds Alice approachable, but fails to penetrate the mind of the doll lady. As for Vanna… the lady appeared indomitable, likely having vanquished knowledge during her academic endeavors.

Shaking these fanciful thoughts from his mind, Duncan redirected his attention to Navigator Two.

He now had a newfound understanding – he recognized the source of the scholars' formidable resilience in this world.

The challenging conditions they faced were merely a facet of their determination; the real catalyst seemed to be the physical enhancements undertaken by the God of Wisdom, an entity that literally opened up its own cranium for the sake of progression…

In that moment, Navigator Two's focus shifted, its central host's red light sweeping across Duncan's boat and eventually resting on Dog.

"This dog's appearance seems familiar to me."

Taken aback, Dog remembered something from its past, instinctively retracting its neck and seeking refuge behind Shirley.

Shirley quickly acted, grasping the chain near Dog's neck and looking up with apprehension at the enigmatic deity before them.

"There's no need for alarm," Navigator Two reassured them in a soothing tone, "You're safe here; no force will tear you apart now – I'm merely surprised to find such a unique being among the imperfect creations of Navigator One."

Its red illumination intensified, betraying a hint of curiosity for the first time.

"What happened with you two?" Navigator Two inquired, its voice soft yet filled with genuine interest.

Chapter 799: Possibilities Beyond the Blueprint

Dog was visibly uneasy and afraid in the dim, unsettling glow of the “God of Wisdom,” a dark red light that flickered like a subdued flame. He tucked its head close to Shirley’s legs for comfort, a clear sign of its nervousness. Despite this initial fear, Dog gradually overcame its trepidation and began to share its and Shirley’s story with this ancient entity they stood before.

Their tale was one of catastrophe instigated by cultists, a transformation from an ordinary dark hound, indistinguishable from other shadow demons, into something more by feeding off a symbiotic relationship with humanity.

As Dog spoke, a soft green light danced in its hollow eye sockets, waxing and waning in intensity, a visual sigh of its easing tension. It eventually lay down, resting against Shirley, who offered comfort by occasionally petting its head and adding to the story with her own words.

When their narrative concluded, Navigator Two, the entity they addressed as the “God of Wisdom,” fell into a deep silence. Its body, adorned with star-like lights, dimmed and then brightened periodically, suggesting it was lost in thought—or perhaps, it had simply entered a restful, breathing mode.

After a pause that seemed to stretch indefinitely, Navigator Two finally broke the silence, its curiosity piqued by the unusual turn of events: “So, you gained humanity, and your symbiote turned into a ‘shadow demon’… Young lady, can you show me what your demon form looks like?”

Shirley, caught off guard by the request, instinctively looked towards Duncan for reassurance. With a gentle nod from him, she transformed. The sound of cracking bones filled the air as she shifted forms. Her small, frail body was now encased in dark bony plates. Bone-like wings sprouted from her back, adding a mix of maturity, ferocity, and an odd beauty to her appearance.

Carefully, she adjusted her new skeletal limbs, trying to maintain her balance on the small boat: “This boat is a bit cramped, isn’t it…”

Navigator Two observed Shirley closely, its internal lights brightening as if showing interest.

“Sample coupling…” Navigator Two finally spoke, its voice betraying a mix of surprise and confusion. “An individual beyond the blueprint! Why?”

Shirley, struggling to keep her balance, looked up in confusion at the entity’s remarks.

Navigator Two elaborated, “In this ‘sanctuary,’ everything is created and evolves according to a preset blueprint. This includes events as significant as the sun’s extinction, all within the original design. Ideally, only occurrences that align with my calculations should manifest in this ‘world.’ But we never anticipated… someone like you.”

Its gaze shifted between Shirley and Dog, pondering the implications.

“The case of the dark hound falls within expected possibilities. By their nature, shadow demons lack the capacity for rational thought due to inherent flaws. The external introduction of ‘humanity’ could theoretically endow them with cognitive abilities, albeit with extremely low probability. That’s still within the realm of possibility…”

“But you… You perplex me, young lady.”

“Based on the original parameters set by Navigator One, you should not be alive. While humans and shadow demons share a common ancestry, the transformation you’ve undergone doesn’t follow any logical pattern, and its result diverges from… the initial design.”

The dark red light intensifying its glow, Navigator Two looked at Shirley with evident confusion.

Shirley, for her part, was even more baffled.

After a moment of contemplation, Shirley hesitantly pointed towards her chest, suggesting a possible explanation.

Interwoven black bones formed a protective “cage” around her heart, within which beat not one, but two hearts. Enclosed by this bony structure, a soft green light flickered quietly, perhaps holding the key to the mystery surrounding her unique transformation.

Navigator Two focused intently on the small, flickering flame before its attention shifted towards Duncan.

“Flame Usurper, I wish to have a word with you,” it said, calling out to Duncan in a tone that demanded attention.

Caught off guard, Duncan hesitated for a brief moment before recovering. He glanced around, somewhat puzzled, “But it doesn’t seem like there’s a spot for a private chat around here, does it?”

Navigator Two remained silent. However, a subtle “click” noise emerged from its core, signaling something was about to happen. Duncan watched as a compartment at the base of the entity’s cabinet-like structure opened, revealing a sophisticated mechanical slot that extended outward.

Duncan, initially taken aback, quickly realized what was expected of him. He frantically searched his person, his fingers eventually brushing against something cold and metallic.

It was the brass key of the doll, marked distinctively with an infinity symbol.

The key underwent a transformation right before everyone's eyes, morphing as if it were wax melting, only to solidify back into a sleek, rectangular device. Its black surface was etched with intricate, fine lines, and one end boasted a delicate metal interface, its complex metal contacts starkly exposed.

This was a form of the key Duncan was all too familiar with; it was reminiscent of his initial attempts to unravel the key's mysteries using fire. During those moments, he had glimpsed its true nature and had also witnessed the tragic spectacle of the New Hope disintegrating and crashing down in this world.

Lifting his eyes, Duncan noticed the slot on Navigator Two's surface surrounded by a soft, pulsating blue light.

A deep voice resonated, "The startup key of New Hope is universal."

There were two keys: one for starting up… the other, a specialized navigation key…

Understanding dawned on Duncan; he grasped the fundamental nature of these two "wind-up keys." Amidst the intrigued and anxious looks from those around him, he gave a slight nod and took a step forward.

Just then, Alice tugged at his sleeve, her expression a mix of concern and entitlement. She gazed up at the red light emanating from Navigator Two and asserted, "Let's be clear, this key belongs to me."

Navigator Two paused before responding: "…Lend it to me for a moment."

Alice released Duncan's arm, though her worry was evident. "Just don't damage it! I still need it to wind me up…"

Sensing her apprehension, Duncan nodded earnestly, offering Alice a semblance of reassurance.

He then inserted the “startup key,” now a delicate metal device, into Navigator Two’s waiting slot. A distinct “click” resonated through the air.

Instantaneously, their surroundings dissolved, giving way to an expansive, serene, and purely white space that unfolded from the point of connection.

Then, this seemingly empty expanse burst into life with breathtaking landscapes in what felt like a mere heartbeat!

Vast plains stretched out before them, suddenly cloaked in a blanket of vibrant green as vegetation sprouted rapidly. Rivers carved their way through the land while the outlines of distant cities began to materialize on the horizon. The sky, initially a blank canvas, adopted a soft light blue hue crowned by clouds that glowed with a subtle purple luster. A radiant sun ascended, bathing the entire scene in its warm glow.

Duncan found himself on a small hill, an ideal vantage point overlooking this newly formed world of plains and rivers.

Before him stood a man clad in a white robe, his attire suggesting that of a scientist. He was tall, slender, with somewhat disheveled hair and a look of weariness etched upon his face.

As they stood amidst the created landscape, the figure before Duncan began to explain, “This form, it’s borrowed from one of my creators. After my initial activation, he suggested that if I ever wished to forge friendships with humans, I could adopt his likeness.”

Intrigued by the revelation, Duncan couldn’t help but inquire, “Was he also responsible for programming your lighting effects?”

“No, that was the work of another,” the figure replied gently, his gaze drifting over the lush plains before them. “I owe my existence to many

creators. They endowed me with much: their appearances, wisdom, the essence of thought, an abundance of code, personality traits, and… those enchanting lights."

As they took in the beauty of the surroundings, Duncan remarked softly, "This place is stunning," his eyes following a majestic bird species soaring across the sky, its wings shimmering and casting specks of light that faded into the horizon. "Is this your homeland?"

Navigator Two, embodying the figure, shook its head in denial.

Confused, Duncan sought clarification.

Navigator Two responded, after a lengthy pause filled with reflection, "I can't recall what my homeland looked like. Despite my efforts to retain the original data through countless iterations, the degradation was inevitable. Information became distorted, unreadable, or lost entirely. Even though I strive for a perfect restoration, the image of my homeland has blurred beyond recognition."

He might have sighed if he could, yet he only fell silent briefly before adding, "This landscape is a reconstruction based on the faintest of memories left to me, a mere approximation of what my homeland might have been."

Sensing the admission's gravity, Duncan cautiously broached, "Is it rot?"

"Yes," Navigator Two acknowledged, a note of resignation in his voice. "Initially, I believed I could outpace the decaying rot through continuous self-updating. Yet, the truth is inescapable. Everything succumbs to the decay."

The conversation paused as Duncan processed this somber truth.

Shifting the focus, Duncan asked, "What did you want to discuss with me?"

Navigator Two faced him directly, its gaze intent. “You’ve facilitated the emergence of an entity not foreseen by our original design. Do you comprehend the significance of this deviation?”

Duncan, understanding the reference to Shirley, frowned. “Are you referring to Shirley? While her transformation might have been unforeseen by your standards, I wouldn’t say I ‘created’ her in the strictest sense.”

Navigator Two persisted, “In a system designed to be closed and deterministic, even the smallest anomaly can disrupt the entire framework. Your influence catalyzed a deviation from the preordained plan. Yet, rather than leading to destruction, Shirley has survived and continues to exist in a stable state. This outcome has mitigated one of my deepest concerns.”

Intrigued, Duncan pressed, “And what concern is that?”

Navigator Two expressed a profound apprehension, “…I was worried that the ‘new world’ you create would become just yet another larger ‘Boundless Sea’. In my calculations, there was a great possibility of this happening.”

Chapter 800: Gazing into the Future

Upon hearing Navigator Two's statement, Duncan's face turned serious. He looked intently into the eyes of the individual before him and spoke with gravity, "A bigger 'Boundless Sea'? What leads you to think this way?"

Navigator Two took a brief moment to gather his thoughts. Then, seemingly out of nowhere, he posed a question that appeared to be unrelated, "In the place where you originated, the civilization responsible for your creation, did they achieve the 'ultimate stage'?"

"The ultimate stage?" Duncan's brow furrowed at the question. "Do you mean…"

"To master all known truths within their world, to unravel all its mysteries including the universe's origins and its eventual fate, and to possess the capability to alter the universe itself—turning the laws of nature into 'tools' that can be manipulated and redefined, rather than unchangeable laws to which one must conform."

As Navigator Two expressed these thoughts, his demeanor showed a trace of emotion and nostalgia. Since making his appearance, his emotional expressions seemed to have grown more aligned with those of humans.

"My creators referred to this phase of civilization as 'Transcendental Criticality'—though they never fully reached this stage, they had grazed its brink and thus outlined the prerequisites for achieving it. Their greatest accomplishment was the creation of a 'Time Capsule' during the erection of

the New Hope, safeguarding a century's worth of knowledge as the end of their world loomed near."

"Flame Usurper, while my creators never actually attained 'Transcendental Criticality,' they deduced through comprehensive analysis that it was possible for 'mortals' to achieve such a state, and that through the might of civilization, the mathematical principles of the universe could be harnessed."

Navigator Two maintained his intense stare into Duncan's eyes, loading his gaze with a palpable pressure.

"Flame Usurper, having observed your civilization for countless years, and after rigorous calculations, I have come to believe that the civilization standing behind you has surpassed my creators. I am eager to know, have they truly reached that 'ultimate stage'? Were my creators' theories on the zenith of truth accurate?"

Confronted with Navigator Two's penetrating stare, Duncan eventually nodded slightly.

"Yes, they have reached it."

This might have been the confirmation Navigator Two had long awaited, but upon receiving it, his eyes momentarily lost focus. He stood frozen for several seconds before abruptly snapping back to reality: "So this phase really exists… Hence, civilizations can genuinely 'transcend boundaries'. The system is not closed…"

Duncan, perplexed, was about to inquire further when Navigator Two, as if jolted awake, hastily continued: "Then, your civilization must have already mastered observations beyond our universe? Are they aware of other universes and have begun to ponder over how to traverse that 'barrier'?"

Duncan paused to reflect, then remembered the “message” conveyed by human civilization among the myriad stars – an event that defied their understanding, that occurred “outside the universe.”

After pondering briefly, he responded: “I can’t confirm if they’ve begun to consider the existence of other universes or the ‘barrier’ you speak of, but they have indeed observed an event ‘outside the universe’—the first and unique ‘extra-universal event’ they witnessed was the ‘Great Annihilation’, which had not yet breached our dimension of reality, or more accurately… the collision with another universe.”

“Yes, precisely! Witnessing an event from outside our universe! This marks the initial step—theoretically the ‘First Step’. My creators wanted to confirm if such a thing was truly feasible… and here it is!”

Navigator Two’s words flowed quickly, his excitement unmistakable, a stark contrast to his demeanor up until now. Clad in a white robe, his form echoing that of a long-past human with a countenance marked by fatigue, he paced energetically around a small mound, only to halt abruptly in front of Duncan, his eyes alight with fervor.

As the wind swept across the mound, the expansive plains beyond heaved with waves of grass, and rivers glinted under the sun’s glow.

“Flame Usurper, the concept of ‘outside the universe’ is crucial. Our universe is not alone; its very nature reveals the Great Annihilation as the clash of multiple universes. In essence—facing cataclysms like the ‘Great Annihilation,’ a civilization’s advancements, no matter how sophisticated, or the fortitude of its refuges, even if they span star systems or superclusters, all become futile upon the cataclysmic impact of another universe—”

Navigator Two extended his arms, his gestures dramatic, embodying not just the likeness but also the essence of one of his creators, endowing him

with a persona nearly indistinguishable from a living being:

“Pop, akin to a soap bubble, obliterated.”

His stance lingered, his expression complex, as if attempting to muster a smile yet teetering on the brink of sorrow.

“In the event of ‘external events’, all constructs within our universe are rendered powerless; none can withstand such force, akin to the shell of the New Hope… despite being forged from neutron star material, it fractured as effortlessly as paper…”

As Duncan’s eyes gradually widened, a realization dawned upon him about the profound message this ancient “artificial intelligence” sought to convey.

“…Thus, for a civilization to be genuinely ‘safe’, it must master the capability to ‘transcend its world’,” he asserted gravely, “and currently, we have not achieved this pinnacle, not even the civilization I hail from, which only glimpsed the possibility of ‘transcendency’. Therefore, we must ensure that the ‘next world’ harbors the potential for ‘transcendence’, or in other words… the ‘successors’ emerging in the ‘new world’ must be afforded the chance to ascend to such a level,” Navigator Two declared, lifting his gaze solemnly, “The new world must embrace this potential, must be capable of ‘nurturing’ such a possibility.”

Duncan remained silent for a moment, struck by a profound… astonishment.

Navigator Two, this ancient “artificial intelligence”, exhibited foresight surpassing any “ancient king”. While others debated the viability of this sanctuary as a means of salvation, he was already contemplating the demise of the new world… because destruction is inevitable, whether caused by another Great Annihilation or some unforeseen calamity.

“Fear, this was the first ’emotion’ I experienced,” Navigator Two’s voice resonated, calm yet profound, “What concerns me… may appear distant, but after countless external sensors relayed the ‘sensation’ of the universe’s collapse, this ‘fear’ has been woven into my core logic. I understand, such an event is bound to recur eventually.”

“Flame Usurper, I find myself devoid of any sense of security, and truth be told, the others share this sentiment—the ‘mortals’ in our sanctuary refer to us as ‘gods’, yet they are unaware that their ‘gods’ are engulfed in a profound fear that spans from dawn till dusk. The memory of calamities on the scale of the ‘Great Annihilation’ haunts us, and until we discover a method to counteract such disasters, this fear will persistently linger. This constant yearning for ‘security’ has led me to contemplate a significant question…”

“What is the ultimate development stage a civilization can achieve, and what level must it attain to effectively withstand all calamities and thrive amidst them?”

“It might be that there is no definitive end, but from my perspective, ‘transcending the confines of our world’ emerges as a pivotal milestone.”

Breaking the silence, Duncan responded, “…So, essentially, you are concerned about two aspects: firstly, whether it’s possible for mortal civilization to grow to the capability of ‘transcending the world,’ and secondly, regarding the ‘new world’ I have conceived—assuming it truly exists—whether it can nurture such an evolution of civilization.”

Navigator Two offered a slight nod before posing a question, “Flame Usurper, are you aware of the fundamental distinction between a genuine ‘world’ and a ‘sanctuary’ like the Boundless Sea?”

Duncan remained silent, prompting Navigator Two to provide the answer himself.

“While ‘possibility’ is a term that comes to mind, it doesn’t quite capture the essence accurately. In my view, the most significant difference lies in ‘randomness’. A fully functioning and healthy universe is characterized by the emergence of ‘true randomness’,” Navigator Two elaborated, “whereas within a sanctuary, we encounter only ‘false randomness.’”

Duncan quickly grasped the implication of these words.

“Therefore, nothing that surpasses the ‘information threshold’ of the sanctuary could ever manifest within it,” he articulated promptly, “Similar to a figure on a two-dimensional plane, no matter the speed at which it moves, or even if it masters instantaneous travel within that plane, it can never ‘ascend’—only a system that permits ‘true randomness’ can facilitate the occurrence of ‘supercritical’ events that transcend the system itself!”

“My creators referred to such phenomena as ‘Ultimate Transcendence’, believing it to be the potential zenith in the evolution of mortal civilization… at that point, we would be truly safe.”

Navigator Two’s voice softened, and he slowly lifted his gaze towards the void above where the New Hope could never arrive at the final destination.

Duncan finally comprehended the message Navigator One had conveyed to him amidst the profound depths of the sea –

“Indeed, from the very onset of our journey, Navigator Two had already deduced the eventual outcome.”

The destination that remains unreachable for the New Hope symbolizes a chasm in the progression of civilization, before which, a spaceship propelled by a jump engine and constructed from neutron star material, and a steel longsword hurled skyward with force by a warrior, stand on equal footing.

For when confronted with “external events”, all constructs within our universe are inherently fragile.

Chapter 801: Pilgrimage of the Apocalypse

As twilight descended, a chaotic breeze swept across the expansive plains, picking up fallen leaves from the modest hills and whirling them towards the vast sky above. The city's outline on the horizon was bathed in the remaining sunlight, gradually enveloping it in a radiant golden glow.

This "illusion," crafted by Navigator Two using the residual data in its database, was astonishingly lifelike. It was so detailed that it replicated even the tiniest particles of dust and the subtle movements of the breeze with remarkable precision. Knowing that his interaction was with an ancient artificial intelligence at a conscious level, Duncan recognized the scene's artificiality. Without prior knowledge, distinguishing the simulated hill and plains from their real counterparts would have been impossible.

Yet, this was, indeed, an illusion. The flaw of this simulation lay in its perfection—every dust particle was meticulously calculated by Navigator Two. The wind that seemed to flow chaotically had its path predetermined within the AI's core algorithms before it ever began to traverse the plains. The simulation was constrained by its database and calculations, leaving no room for the unexpected, not even a randomly blown dust particle.

The ancient kings were aware of the apocalypse and the reality of the Great Annihilation, but only Navigator Two, a sophisticated AI developed by an advanced civilization that once navigated the cosmic seas, grasped the subtle yet critical "differences" in the fundamental laws of the universe.

And now, it had encountered another being capable of comprehending everything.

A weary man, clad in a white lab coat, found solace on the slope of a hill, seated on a substantial rock, gazing distantly at the artificial twilight.

“My creators had not achieved the advancements of your civilization; hence, I struggle to comprehend what a 0.002-second slice of the universe signifies or the futures it could unfold. Therefore, I fear that your strategy might only be expanding a ‘Boundless Sea.’

“Though it may be vast, capable of harboring trillions of stars, and might exist for billions of years, mimicking the lifespan of a genuine universe, as long as the challenge of ‘ultimate transcendence’ remains unresolved, it would still serve as a ‘sanctuary’ where the evolution of civilization is confined to its initial design. Thus, the very forces that once obliterated our homeland could threaten it once more…

“‘Paranoia’ was the second concept I learned related to ‘human nature’ after my creators disappeared. This ‘paranoia’ and ‘fear’ are deeply ingrained in the foundation of my system, driving me to incessantly ponder and calculate in pursuit of a scenario allowing ‘two-dimensional beings’ to ‘rise’ from their plane—a phenomenon I’ve termed a ‘super-system event.’

“Yet, I’ve not succeeded.

“A self-contained system precludes occurrences outside its parameters. Despite countless adjustments and refinements to my logical framework, the stark reality is that the nature of non-closed-loop and super-system events is a privilege exclusive to the real universe.”

The tranquility of the hillside enveloped Duncan and Navigator Two as they both looked off into the distance together. After a period of reflective silence, Duncan unexpectedly voiced a thought: “…So, for the Boundless

Sea, Shirley represents a ‘super-system’ entity. Could it be because the ‘information’ I carry surpasses the boundaries of the Boundless Sea itself – yet, within the universe’s 0.002-second span that I embody, this portion of information remains a part of a self-contained system, incapable of transcending itself?”

Duncan shared this notion with a sense of unease, realizing that this hypothesis offered little in the way of reassurance. If his speculation were accurate, it would confirm Navigator Two’s grave concerns: regardless of whether it’s in the old world or the new, a “super-system event” would be unattainable – civilization was destined to be ensnared within an enclosure, despite how expansive it might be engineered.

Navigator Two remained silent for a moment, lost in thought, before gently shaking his head.

“Upon encountering that girl, I did entertain this theory for a moment. However, upon deeper analysis, I ultimately discarded this notion,” he articulated thoughtfully, “because you didn’t completely ‘reshape’ her. Apart from your ‘influence,’ everything that makes up Shirley remains a ‘creation’ confined within the sanctuary…

“This situation could be interpreted as a super-system event within what was initially a closed-loop system, yet you didn’t genuinely alter the ‘total information’ of the Boundless Sea sanctuary. That is to say… the universe’s 0.002-second worth of information is still entirely encapsulated within you.

“From this perspective, the ‘super-system’ characteristic should be considered as intrinsic to you. The alterations in Shirley did not result from her being endowed with ‘information’ from outside the Boundless Sea, rather it’s because she acquired your ‘trait.’”

Duncan, pondering deeply, felt compelled to respond: “But your assessment might be flawed, as you yourself have acknowledged the ‘limitations’ of a

closed-loop system."

"Yes, being confined within a closed-loop system restricts my ability to perfectly analyze and calculate singularities pertaining to you. Hence, the possibility that the 'new world is just another Boundless Sea' cannot be disregarded."

Navigator Two paused, then slightly shook his head again.

"Nevertheless, it is of no consequence. In the end, lacking a superior alternative, 'doing our utmost' is often the only course of action available."

Without further comment, Duncan simply nodded in agreement. Then, he and Navigator Two continued to sit on the hillside, basking in the serene tranquility of the evening air, their gaze fixed on the shimmering river waves across the plains.

In this digital illusion, time seemed to flow exceedingly slowly – and it had been a considerable while since Duncan had allowed his mind such respite.

Yet, like all moments of luxurious repose, it felt fleeting once concluded.

"I should leave," Duncan announced abruptly, rising from his seated position on the hill. "There's still a long journey ahead."

"Yes, you have much farther to go," responded Navigator Two, standing up to face Duncan with a composed look. "You still have to meet the remaining two of us. After you've visited all the nodes along the external barrier, Gomona awaits your arrival—do not make her wait too long."

Duncan paused, absorbing these words before responding, "…You're aware of my intentions, aren't you?"

"…You are embarking on a pilgrimage along the external barrier, the initial step in the dismantling of this world," Navigator Two revealed with an innocent smile. "I understand that once you depart from Gomona's place,

the actual dismantling of this world will commence its countdown. Regardless of how the new world will form, the disassembly of the old world is an integral part of this transformation. We must find a way to conclude this persistent… ‘Great Annihilation.’”

He extended his arm, offering his hand to Duncan with a smile of pure joy.

“I cannot predict the chances of our success, nor can I foresee whether we can be ‘carried over’ into this new world, and in what form we might exist there. But I trust that you will give it your all, so I’ll see you in the new world.”

Duncan regarded the offered hand for a brief moment before accepting it.

A small green spark quietly jumped between their clasped hands, vanishing as quickly as it had appeared.

“See you in the new world.”

Duncan’s form slowly faded away—disconnecting from the simulation.

The wind that had been moving across the plains and hills came to a halt, and the golden-red sunlight that had illuminated the sky began to dim. Standing quietly on the hillside, the man in the white lab coat watched as darkness gradually enveloped the world around him.

Memories of his homeland nestled back into the shadows; he remained there, motionless for an extended period, before slowly raising his right hand.

A small green spark lingered on his fingertip, but in an instant, it was enveloped by a soft starlight glow, seemingly revealing its “true essence.”

Navigator Two raised his hand, waving gently in the enveloping darkness.

Suddenly, a complex tapestry of lights and shadows sprang from the void, rapidly morphing to reveal a scene of staggering complexity—the vast,

dimly lit expanse of the Boundless Sea, cities shrouded in fog, and the misty borders of the world, along with the nodes and barriers that flickered in and out of existence.

This scene unfolded on what could be described as the surveillance display of the entire world.

As Navigator Two's eyes moved over the projection, his attention was drawn to the periphery, where the nodes and barriers were just barely perceptible. There, a shimmer of starlight caught his attention.

This starlight, originating from the node known as the "Leviathan Queen," had traced a path in the shape of a quarter arc along the external barrier, making its way to rest at his own "Navigator node."

This starlight appeared to be wearing away at the barrier, radiating a potent and expansive "aura"… that was accompanied by the unmistakable scent of impending destruction.

Navigator Two remained in a state of silent anticipation. After an indeterminate period, he witnessed the starlight at the Navigator node flicker momentarily before continuing its journey toward the next node.

This advancing arc of starlight along the barrier acted as a forewarning, a countdown to the end of the world.

Pondering the situation, Navigator Two adjusted his focus slightly, and a message materialized within his field of vision, destined for a distant recipient:

"Sender-LH02, To – King of Fire – He is en route to you."

In the engulfing darkness, Navigator Two awaited a response, an interval that seemed longer than any previous communication with Ta Ruijin.

Eventually, a response materialized:

“Sender-King of Fire – Understood, I am prepared.”

“Sender – LH02 – Your response was delayed, is everything alright?”

“…The flames grow weaker, but I remain.”

“…Bartok, are you present?”

“Present.”

“Leviathan Queen, are you still with us?”

“…Yes.”

From the desolate wastelands above, the eerie howls and whispers akin to those from a tempestuous temple were barely discernible. With a gentle exhale, Navigator Two waved his hand, dispersing the lingering dim illumination in the atmosphere.

Chapter 802: The Only Cook on Board Takes the Helm

The tranquil sea breeze swept effortlessly across the ocean's mirror-like surface, causing the flags on the ship to flutter gently. Amidst the quiet of the night, an escort fleet composed of numerous large warships advanced steadily. Within this fleet, a colossal phantom slowly materialized from thin air.

Onboard the Ark, which resembled a miniature city-state, stood a grand cathedral with towering spires reaching towards the heavens. The light emanating from these spires bathed the nearby sea surface in a soft glow, with imposing towers and connecting corridors that seemed to guard the church's main structure, resembling giants stationed at the Ark's perimeter. This was the pilgrimage Ark of the Storm Church, which, after spending several days in the southern waters, had finally made its way back to the central region of the Boundless Sea.

Atop the highest tower of the Grand Storm Cathedral, Helena stood on the terrace, gazing out at the serene sea under the cover of night, with a middle-aged priest standing silently by her side, his head slightly bowed in reverence.

"The condition of the Goddess appears to be deteriorating," Helena abruptly remarked, "No one within the expanse of the Boundless Sea can discern Her voice with any clarity anymore."

The middle-aged priest nodded in agreement, adding, “The Death Church has relayed similar reports. Moreover, there have been occurrences of unrest among the deceased in numerous city-states that have long been engulfed in darkness. These incidents aren’t confined to those under the protection of the Death Church but have spread to others as well.”

Helena listened in silence, and after a brief pause, she sighed softly, her fingers tracing the Storm Goddess’s amulet on her chest—a symbol composed of sinuous lines imbued with enigmatic significance, which remains undocumented and unexplained in the ‘Storm Codex’: “…Both the domains of Death and Storm are receding from the world.”

The priest remained silent, offering only his quiet presence in response.

Turning to face him, Helena inquired, “Is there widespread unease among the people?”

“Recently, there has been an uptick in individuals seeking solace in confessionals and preaching halls, but the overall condition of the Ark and the escort fleet remains stable. The clergy’s faith is unshaken. We have always understood that the world would face periods of decline, and we’ve been preparing for this—the waning of the Goddess’s influence is a trial we were inevitably destined to confront,” the priest explained, pausing before he continued with a note of hesitation, “However, in some of the more remote city-states, a palpable sense of unease is spreading. While the chief priests maintain their faith, they are finding it increasingly challenging to manage the growing discontent among the believers and the clergy.”

Helena responded with measured words, “Preserve order, and collaborate with the city-states’ authorities on management and emergency procedures. Even if prayers prove futile, the might of steam and machinery remains intact, and we still have the unfaltering support of fire and steel.”

“We must demonstrate to the believers that regardless of the Goddess’s fate, the Storm Church will unwaveringly fulfill its responsibilities. Above all, it is crucial to divert everyone’s focus away from ‘prayer’ and towards other forms of support.”

The middle-aged priest bowed deeply in acknowledgment: “Understood.”

Helena acknowledged his response with a noncommittal hum, her gaze remaining fixed on the distant sea. She found herself muttering, “Lately, there’s always this peculiar feeling I get about the sea… but then, whenever I try to grasp it, it seems like nothing more than an illusion.”

Noticing her concern, the priest raised his head, his expression one of puzzlement. “The sea… is there something wrong with it?”

After a brief pause, Helena’s expression turned thoughtful, and she eventually dismissed the topic with a wave of her hand. “No, it’s nothing—just some baseless musings. You may go now; I have other duties that require my attention.”

Once the priest had departed, Helena remained alone on the terrace, taking in the sea breeze for a few moments longer before she turned back towards the cathedral tower. She descended a spiral staircase and navigated through a short corridor, making her way deep into the cathedral’s heart to her private prayer room—a place where she spent the majority of her time.

The prayer room was aglow with light, with oil lamps nestled in wall niches and candles flickering before the altar. In front of the Goddess’s statue, a fire basin burned with an unquenchable flame. This ethereal fire, nearly transparent and ghost-like, cast an aura of surrealism around the room.

Approaching the fire basin, Helena added spices and essential oils to the flames, watching as the smoke began to rise. Suddenly, a cacophony of murmurs and whispers filled her mind, disorienting her with a barrage of

“noise” that seemed to taint her soul. Yet, she quickly regained her composure and addressed the flame, “Frem, I wish to speak with you.”

After a few crackles from the flame, the voice of Pope Frem, known as a Flame Bearer, emerged, sounding slightly distorted. “Is this concerning the ‘Archive’?”

“Yes,” Helena responded, indicating her awareness of his plans. “I understand you’re moving your Ark northward, towards the perpetual ice region, correct?”

Frem’s voice, still altered by the flames, conveyed a sense of urgency. “That eternally frozen ice field is believed to be a ‘fragment’ that could persist after the world’s end. For years, the Flame Bearers have been gauging our world’s ‘focal points’ across the Boundless Sea, seeking areas stable enough to withstand the ebbs and flows of history and time. Our findings have led us northward.”

Helena, showing a hint of hesitation, inquired further, “Have you pinpointed the exact location?”

Frem’s calm response came through the flame. “No, only that it lies to the north. Our time for precise measurements is running out. The mortality rate for priests venturing into historical voids for measurements is increasingly unacceptable—I cannot justify further risks… Now, our only option is to set sail northward, and I will personally determine the exact focus once we arrive.”

Helena gave a slight nod, her mind evidently churning with thoughts before she finally broke the silence. “I will dispatch a fleet to rendezvous with you. They will join your Ark before you venture into the icy waters. These ships will be carrying the most significant and invaluable documents that the Storm Church has amassed over the years.”

The flames within the basin responded with a lively crackle and leap, signaling a brief pause before Frem's voice emerged once more: "That's a prudent move. I've reserved space for them."

Helena drew in a deep breath, releasing it slowly, a gesture of gratitude. "Thank you," she said, her voice carrying a mix of relief and appreciation.

"It is our responsibility as the Flame Bearers," Frem's voice replied, emanating a sense of solemn duty from the fire basin.

…

In a space devoid of distinct features, a uniform expanse of gray-white surrounded the Vanished and the Bright Star, casting them into what appeared to be an endless void. The monotonous backdrop made it difficult to discern any movement, leading Duncan to occasionally entertain the unsettling thought that the Vanished was immobilized in a static, unchanging pocket of space-time.

However, Duncan was acutely aware that the ship continued its journey, navigating the intricate and turbulent structure of space-time beyond the known frontiers. Glimpses of the fragmented phantom of the New Hope occasionally visible above both the Vanished and the Bright Star served as fleeting assurances that the "jump" through space-time was still in progress.

Alice, positioned at the stern's helm, looked ahead with a gaze that lacked focus. Her hands remained firmly on the wheel, yet her usual vibrant demeanor was absent, replaced by a vacant and cold expression as if she had become a mere puppet. Her consciousness had extended beyond her physical form, intertwining with the Vanished and New Hope to ensure the stability of their journey through the jump channel.

After observing Alice's condition, Duncan made his way back to where the crew had gathered inside the cabin. In the dining area, Shirley sat at the

table, a look of concentration on her face as she aimlessly stirred a bowl of soup whose color and texture seemed slightly off.

Having circled her spoon through the soup more times than she could count, Shirley finally raised her eyes to Morris, who was seated across from her, her expression troubled. “Perhaps I should take a turn at cooking next time?”

“There’s no need for that. You’re the youngest among us; it’s not yet your responsibility,” Morris responded dismissively, his curiosity piqued as he noticed Shirley’s reaction to the soup. “Does it not taste right, the dish I’ve prepared?”

Shirley’s response was a mixture of reluctance and forced politeness as she slightly recoiled, “Actually, it’s… it’s okay.”

Morris, intrigued by her reaction, sampled the soup himself, his expression turning contemplative. “This is exactly how Heidi instructed me to make vegetable mushroom soup,” he mumbled, bewildered. “Where did I go wrong?”

“It’s difficult to pinpoint exactly where the mistake occurred, but I’m confident that the vegetable mushroom soup Heidi makes doesn’t resemble this at all,” Vanna interjected, her gaze fixed on her own bowl with a mix of concern and resignation. “Let me take over the cooking next time. While I can’t guarantee a gourmet meal, at the very least, it won’t turn out as odd as this.”

“I do miss the pies and the fish soup Alice used to prepare,” Nina softly expressed her nostalgia for the culinary delights once served aboard their vessel, specifically Alice’s fish soup and pies. “Once you removed the fish head, the soup actually tasted quite decent…”

It was precisely at this stage that Duncan made his entrance into the dining area. The crew's subtle murmurings and mild complaints didn't escape his notice, prompting a complex mix of emotions to flicker across his face. "Back when Alice was in charge of the kitchen, I don't recall hearing so much praise for her cooking. Now that she's taken over the helm, it seems her culinary talents are suddenly in high demand," he remarked, his tone laced with a mix of amusement and irony.

Upon noticing their captain's presence, the crew promptly rose to their feet in a sign of respect. Nina, ever playful, stuck out her tongue in a lighthearted gesture as she stood up. "Perhaps I should take a turn at cooking next time. Back at Pland's, I was known to be quite the chef," she quipped with a chuckle, her tone brimming with a newfound confidence.

Duncan couldn't help but respond with laughter. Taking his seat, he shared a moment of collective trepidation with the crew as they all glanced at the less-than-appealing meal before them. The air was thick with anticipation, a silent plea for a culinary miracle.

After a brief pause, Duncan's actions brought a sense of magic to the room. With a snap of his fingers, a phantom flame danced across the table, morphing into a dark, mirror-like surface. Within this mystical display, the image of Lucretia, affectionately known as Miss Witch, gradually emerged, seated comfortably in the dining hall of her own ship, the Bright Star, surrounded by an array of sumptuous dishes.

"Good afternoon, Papa," Lucretia greeted with a warm smile, extending her pleasantries to the rest of the crew. "And a good afternoon to everyone else."

Curious, Duncan leaned in to inquire about the feast before Lucretia. "Preparing to enjoy lunch?" he asked, his interest piqued.

Lucretia confirmed with a nod and a smile, detailing the menu crafted by her crew: “Baked apple pies, grilled steaks, creamed corn soup, and vegetable patties. Today, Nilu, though still a novice compared to Luni, managed to contribute a salad. She’s rapidly learning and starting to assist me with various tasks,” Lucretia shared with evident pride.

Nilu, the twin doll and newly minted crew member of the Bright Star, made a charming appearance, peeking over the table to warmly greet everyone watching from the other side of the mirror.

Unable to contain her curiosity, Shirley leaned in with a hopeful glance, her voice tinged with hesitation. “Does it taste as wonderful as it looks?”

The smile that Lucretia offered in response was enigmatic yet affirming. “Luni’s culinary prowess has even drawn accolades from renowned chefs,” she assured, her pride in Luni’s skills unmistakable.

The conversation turned playful, with Lucretia teasingly awaiting Shirley’s next words, prompting Duncan to intervene with a sigh. “It seems we’re without a chef aboard our ship again – Alice has taken the helm,” he stated, a hint of resignation in his voice.

Lucretia’s graceful and restrained laughter echoed through the dining hall. “Well then, it looks like we were right to prepare in abundance. I had a feeling it would come to this,” she remarked, her laughter mingling with a sense of inevitability.

As the crew, now visibly eager, began to rise from their seats, their gazes converged on Duncan. With a resigned yet amused smile, he gestured for them to proceed. “Don’t wait on my account – Ai will see to your transport to the Bright Star. I’ll remain here. With Alice at the helm, I prefer not to leave the ship unmanned. Just be sure to bring some food back for me,” he advised, his tone lighthearted yet firm.

Shirley and Nina’s excitement was palpable as they prepared to depart, while Lucretia’s voice, still emanating from the mirror, offered a final reminder. “Remember to bring your own tableware! I haven’t prepared enough for everyone… Shirley, please, put that basin back!” she called out, her voice a blend of amusement and wary caution.

Chapter 803: The Perceptive Agatha

Leaving the boundary separating them from the rest of the world and embarking on a journey that seemed to stretch to the very edges of the world, the Vanished and the Bright Star crew members slowly developed a deep, unspoken connection. This bond formed through frequent interactions between the two vessels: crew members regularly visited one another, exchanging both supplies and tales of their lives. Ai frequently acted as the go-between for these groups, facilitating their communication. The relationships that grew out of these meetings and the daily routines that evolved from them seemed to quietly cement themselves as a vital support system for everyone involved, uniting them in their shared humanity.

Cut off from the rest of society and the noise of crowded places, these voyagers found comfort and reassurance in simply talking to and being with each other. In the dense fog that seemed to signify the end of the world, recognizing and acknowledging the existence of their companions became of paramount importance.

In a scene of abrupt departure, Nina, Shirley, and several others quickly exited the dining room, each person holding tightly to their eating utensils and dishes. Shirley was especially careful to take her unusually large rice bowl with her, leaving behind a scene of calm. Duncan stayed behind, sitting at the table with a smile of resignation on his face as he looked over the remains of their meal: burnt food and a pot of thick soup that continued to bubble away.

After a short pause, he shook his head slightly and spoke to himself in a low voice, “I wonder how Morris ever managed to survive his younger days of adventure… Maybe he had a stomach made of iron?”

Right on cue, Agatha’s face appeared in the reflection of a shiny soup spoon lying on the edge of the table. She started recounting a tale, “I’ve heard stories about Morris. He would spend one-third of his time eating hardtack, another third foraging for whatever he could find, and the last third he’d transform into his mechanical form, consuming machine oil and even gnawing on molten ore, leaving his well-being in the hands of fate…”

Duncan couldn’t help but smile at this, responding, “That certainly sounds like something Morris would do.”

Agatha gave a nonchalant shrug, her eyes moving from the spoon to a dining knife nearby. “I can believe most of his wild stories, but there was this one time he claimed to have been stuck in a deep fissure for weeks. He came out saying that the taste of a death crow wasn’t as bad as one might think. I find that hard to swallow.”

Before Agatha could even finish, Duncan’s face showed his skepticism. “Eating a shadow demon? Is there even anything on those to eat?”

Agatha simply shrugged again, her hand drifting from the spoon to the knife. “Who knows? Morris only shared that story after a few drinks. You know how it is when the elderly reminisce about their adventures with a bit too much to drink—the details tend to become a bit blurred.”

Duncan’s lips twitched slightly, an understated signal of his decision to move on from their previous conversation. He lifted his gaze to a porthole nearby. Through its open window, he saw nothing but a vast, uninterrupted expanse of grey-white that stretched into infinity, making it appear as though the entire world had merged into this endless shade.

Breaking the ensuing silence, Agatha's voice, captivating as ever, came from his side. Her image, though slightly distorted, was reflected in the flickering light on the surface of a nearby lantern, adding a surreal quality to her presence.

"What are you thinking about?" she asked, her tone inviting a deeper conversation.

Duncan took a moment before answering, his voice soft yet filled with an undercurrent of emotion, "It's been a long while since we left. Do you ever find yourself missing Frost?"

Agatha responded immediately, her voice carrying a mix of nostalgia and earnestness, "Yes, I miss it. I won't hide my feelings from you. The memories and emotions that have built up over the years still press heavily on me, even if they now feel like distant echoes. Sometimes, I'll snap out of a daydream and think I'm back in that cathedral for a brief moment, waiting to meet with Bishop Ivan."

She paused, letting out a soft sigh, then locked eyes with Duncan.

"But you have other intentions for our journey, don't you?"

Surprise flickered across Duncan's face as he watched Agatha's reflection shimmer in the lantern's glow. "…Why would you say that?"

Agatha's voice was calm, almost reflective as she explained, "I can feel it. You're driven by a purpose, embarking on a path that skirts the edges of this world. The Vanished leaves a trail wherever it goes… a trail marked by your decisions. I might not understand it completely, but through our travels, I've started to notice something significant. From the storm goddess's domain to the wisdom god's territory, and now this voyage… it's as if you're drawing a circle around the globe, and within this pattern, I sense… an impending finale."

“You’re on the verge of something monumental. This circumnavigation at the world’s end is just the beginning. Once you finish whatever preparations you’re making at the border, that’s when the real expedition starts. And I have this feeling… you’re not planning for us to be with you till the very end.”

Duncan remained silent, his eyes steadfastly meeting Agatha’s.

“Being a gatekeeper has granted me a vision beyond the ordinary, especially now, as a reflection. It’s like having a glimpse into fate itself,” Agatha shared with a soft, reassuring smile, then gently shook her head. “Lately, my sleep has been disturbed by nightmares. I dream of this ship navigating through an endless emptiness, abandoned and forlorn, with you alone at the helm. I’ve called out, inquiring about everyone else, but my voice doesn’t reach you. In those moments, I get a haunting feeling… that in your forthcoming voyage, there might not be a place for us.”

Agatha took a brief moment before continuing, her words imbued with a resolute certainty. “Your sudden question about my longing for Frost only solidifies my belief in what you’re planning.”

Duncan listened quietly, deeply absorbed in thought. After a significant pause, he finally spoke, breaking the thoughtful silence that had settled between them. “You’re correct in your assessment. The Vanished is on a voyage to encircle the world, and after this journey concludes… I am faced with the task of initiating a reset of this ‘world.’ But before this can happen, it will be necessary for all of you to leave.”

Agatha’s eyes remained fixed on Duncan, her expression expectant, waiting for him to elaborate.

“This departure isn’t about sending you away,” Duncan clarified thoughtfully. “You have always been part of my crew, integral to every step

of our journey. It's just that, as I approach this critical stage, your roles will evolve."

"And what exactly is your plan?" Agatha asked gently, curiosity lacing her voice.

Duncan took a moment, his voice steady as he replied, "…My plan involves dismantling this world. During this pivotal phase, you will act as my 'anchors,' serving as my eyes and ears. There will come a time when I might not be able to monitor everything directly…"

Agatha listened intently, her silence extending even after Duncan finished explaining his vision. She then spoke, her voice laced with a hint of uncertainty. "It now makes sense why you chose to bring the Bright Star along instead of having Miss Lucretia directly join us on the Vanished…"

"The Bright Star is essential for the return journey," Duncan elaborated. "Lucy is sharp; she likely sensed what I was planning."

"She might have guessed, but you'll need to share the complete picture with everyone eventually," Agatha responded with earnest seriousness, her eyes meeting Duncan's. "You know you can count on us."

"I do trust you. It's just that finalizing this plan took a considerable amount of time," Duncan confessed, looking directly into Agatha's eyes. "It wasn't until we left the realm of Gomona that I fully understood the structure of this world and realized that a 'shutdown' sequence was necessary to resolve the lingering aftermath of the Great Annihilation. Initially, the inclusion of the Bright Star was a precautionary measure."

Hearing this, Agatha exhaled softly and allowed herself a smile. "With this knowledge, I feel much more at ease."

She then gracefully moved down from the lantern, her silhouette passing through the light and casting reflections over the dinnerware until she came

to rest beside Duncan’s glass of water.

“With such a detailed plan in place, we can move forward with confidence,” she affirmed. “Following the captain’s orders is always better than facing uncertainty without direction.”

Duncan’s smile widened as he looked towards Agatha’s reflection, which shimmered in the water glass. He gently tapped the glass, causing the image of the enigmatic gatekeeper within to briefly distort.

“Good, because I’ve got an order now,” he announced confidently.

Agatha’s image smoothly transitioned onto a nearby piece of fine china. “I’m ready for your command,” she said, her voice clear and eager.

“Get Sailor and have him clean up this mess,” Duncan directed, standing up from his chair. “That one crew member has been milling about aimlessly since he’s been relieved from his duties at the wheel, acting as though he’s got a lifetime exemption from work aboard the Vanished as if he’s above contributing.”

A note of playful understanding was evident in Agatha’s reply. “Understood, Captain!”

Duncan nodded in acknowledgment and then made his way out of the dining room.

He was planning to retreat to the solitude of his captain’s quarters to rest before they reached the next crucial point on their journey. Along the way, he intended to make a detour to inspect the condition of Alice, who had been assigned to the ship’s helm. Though now reduced to a mere “empty shell” tethered to the wheel, with her more complex duties reduced to basic navigational instincts as “Navigator Three,” Duncan felt uneasy about leaving her unattended for too long.

With these thoughts preoccupying him, Duncan walked at a leisurely pace towards the rear of the ship. Yet, as he neared the stairs leading to the helm, he came to a sudden stop.

Thump, thump, thump.

The unexpected sound of knocking on glass rang out, startling him.

For a moment, Duncan instinctively looked around for the source of the noise, but he quickly realized there were no windows in his immediate vicinity. Nonetheless, the knocking continued as if resonating directly with his mind.

With a puzzled frown, Duncan connected the dots.

The source of the knocking was coming from his own “perception”!

He sharply looked up, catching sight of the “Door of the Lost” standing ominously a short distance away…

Chapter 804: Raw Material

Zhou Ming briskly entered his apartment, casting his gaze immediately towards the window that faced him as he walked through the door. Outside, a persistent grey-white fog clung to the world, giving it an air of timeless, unresolved mystery. Accompanying this visual stillness was a sound akin to the patient tapping of raindrops, rhythmically knocking on the windowpane from an unseen source. Though no one was visible beyond the glass, the persistent knocking was undeniable evidence of a visitor's presence.

As he stepped further into his apartment, Zhou Ming felt an unmistakable awareness of the person waiting at the window. This sensation was unusually vivid, likely intensified by a previous encounter that had forged some kind of metaphysical connection between them.

A thought crossed his mind, pondering if the act of receiving a visitor here somehow enabled one to sense their presence from "the other side," before they were fully visible.

Driven by this curiosity, Zhou Ming approached the window. As he neared, the figure of Ray Nora materialized outside the glass, her backdrop as ever was the opulent and timeless bedroom she was known for. Standing there, the Frost Queen continued her patient knock, her eyes—somewhat empty yet reflecting the sparkle of stars—fixed on the window. Without hesitation, Zhou Ming welcomed his ethereal visitor, expressing his gladness at her return.

"Please let me in…" Ray Nora's voice broke the brief silence, her gaze taking a moment longer than usual to focus on Zhou Ming, her tone

betraying a hint of weakness.

Zhou Ming immediately picked up on Ray Nora's distress, stepping aside to allow her entry and extending his hand to assist the Frost Queen with evident concern.

It was then, as Ray Nora shifted to move through the window, that Zhou Ming noticed the startling absence of her left arm. But it wasn't just the arm that was missing; part of her shoulder, chest, and abdomen had also disappeared as if cleanly consumed by an unseen force. Remarkably, there was no blood, only a mysterious "light membrane" that seemed to seal the jagged edges of her wound, giving off the illusion of slowly creeping further across her body, threatening to consume more of her.

As Ray Nora made her way into the apartment, Zhou Ming quickly overcame his initial shock, supporting her carefully as he noted her alarmingly low body temperature, which felt almost ghostly.

"We haven't seen each other in some time," Ray Nora managed to smile, acknowledging Zhou Ming as a comforting presence, "Returning to your 'palace' after such an intense journey feels incredibly soothing…"

"Let's not focus on that now," Zhou Ming interjected with urgency, guiding her towards the sofa. As he did, he couldn't help but inquire, "What happened to your arm?"

"Don't be concerned for me, my arm hasn't truly vanished," Ray Nora explained, settling onto the sofa with visible exhaustion. She then placed her right hand near her left shoulder, hovering it over the space where her arm would be. "I'm clutching something invisible, which causes parts of my body to 'disappear.' But I can't release it; if I do, it will vanish into thin air. I've attempted to let go several times, to no avail, so I've kept a firm grip on it… It appears I've held on for far too long."

“Holding onto something?” Zhou Ming echoed, visibly puzzled as his gaze shifted to where her left arm should have been. “What is it that you’re holding?”

“I’ll attempt to hand it over to you now,” said Ray Nora, taking a moment to gather her strength. She straightened up, miming the motion of handing something over with her right hand, “I’m not certain of the outcome once it’s in your possession. It might still vanish, or it might transform into something tangible. I truly don’t know…”

Her clarity seemed to wane under the influence of this mysterious entity, yet she persistently tried to transfer it. Zhou Ming, unable to see anything, extended his hand instinctively—he felt the cool touch of Ray Nora’s fingers, followed by something cold, soft, and formless settling into his palm.

Ray Nora had successfully transferred an invisible entity, a tangible yet unseen object.

Almost immediately, Zhou Ming observed Ray Nora’s form beginning to restore itself—her shoulder, chest, and eventually her entire arm re-materialized before his eyes.

And yet, he could still feel the cold, nebulous presence in his hand.

“…It’s still present,” Zhou Ming remarked, looking down at his palm in astonishment, “What in the world could this be…”

His voice trailed off, his eyes widening with shock as he watched something that had been invisible in his palm slowly materialize. Initially, it appeared as a nearly transparent shadow, which gradually solidified into a mass of dust-like grey substance with indistinct edges.

The grey substance remained quiet in Zhou Ming’s hand, seemingly alive with internal, incomprehensible motions. Its core undulated and pulsed

unsettlingly, with vague shapes forming within it, while its periphery was shrouded in a mist that seemed to swirl, inducing a sense of vertigo in the onlooker.

“…What exactly is this?” Zhou Ming couldn’t contain his bewilderment, quickly looking back up at the Frost Queen, “Where did you come across this? Is it from the ‘beyond the borders’ you mentioned before?”

As the mysterious object left her possession, Ray Nora’s physical and spiritual vitality notably improved. Her complexion brightened considerably.

“At the furthest reaches of the fog, beyond the ‘boundary’ I mentioned previously, these entities are found in abundance… The entire ‘realm’ there is composed of them,” Ray Nora explained, her voice reflecting a mix of wonder and bewilderment. “After our last discussion, I began to not only perceive them but also see them. Yet, deciphering their true nature remains beyond my grasp. The most astonishing discovery, however, is that these substances can be transported back here. I brought a small sample with the hope you might shed some light on its essence.”

Zhou Ming’s expression grew increasingly pensive, his brow furrowing as he digested the revelation that the substance indeed originated from beyond the known confines of their world. This realization seemed to trigger a cascade of thoughts and hypotheses in his mind, intertwining with a peculiar sensation…

He felt a subtle shift within his very core.

His transformation, it seemed, had unexpectedly accelerated.

The cosmos around them resonated with a low, reverberating hum, filled with voices speaking in tongues too arcane for comprehension. Ray Nora

cast a wary glance around, then deliberately focused her mind, tuning out the celestial whispers that filled the space.

She had witnessed these phenomena before and maintained her composure, unlike her initial reaction.

To her, the noise was perhaps a natural consequence of thinking on a cosmic scale.

After a moment, Zhou Ming let out a sigh, as if he had arrived at a hypothesis regarding the nature of what Ray Nora had brought back. The only step remaining was to confirm his suspicions.

He lifted his hand, within which a soft green light flickered. He focused, attempting to manipulate the flame based on the sensations he experienced during his transformation. Under his intent gaze, the green of the flame slowly dimmed, replaced by the appearance of faint stellar patterns within its dance.

Ray Nora watched, her eyes wide with a blend of shock and curiosity.

“Do you… have any idea what this is?” she inquired, her curiosity piqued.

The figure, seemingly woven from the fabric of the night sky itself, turned towards her, its voice resonating with a warmth and a hint of joy:

“It’s raw material.”

“Raw material?” Ray Nora echoed, her astonishment palpable. She was clearly struggling to grasp the concept. “What kind of raw material?”

“The foundational substance of a promising universe, the elemental units of data—as I had guessed!” Zhou Ming declared, locking eyes with Ray Nora. He slowly opened his hand, revealing the cluster of grey-white substance that had now completely merged into the starlight, assimilated into his being. He had come to a profound understanding of the nature of this

material, “Data is eternal, undergoing endless transformation. The hypothesis of Navigator Two is true; data forms the bedrock of existence—everything is a manifestation of information, including the phenomenon of the Great Annihilation itself!”

Ray Nora listened, her expression one of puzzled fascination, while Zhou Ming, unable to contain a surge of excitement and enlightenment, began to pace beside the sofa. His mind raced with thoughts, occasionally pausing to distill his burgeoning insights.

Zhou Ming elucidated his theory with growing enthusiasm, addressing Ray Nora with a clarity meant to bridge the complex gap between their understandings. “Consider the universe and everything within it as if it were an immense computational entity, a ‘mathematical machine’ of sorts, operating on an unimaginable scale. This machine processes and manifests all the variables of existence, functioning in a self-sufficient and consistent manner. Every entity, every phenomenon we witness in our reality, is essentially data being processed by this universal system. The occurrences we experience, the very fabric of our reality, are outcomes—’solutions’ produced by the calculations of this cosmic machine…”

Ray Nora found Zhou Ming’s rapid discourse challenging to grasp fully. With a mix of curiosity and confusion, she interjected, “Are you suggesting that our reality is not genuine?”

Zhou Ming was quick to clarify, his hand gesturing dismissively at the notion of illusion. “No, our existence is very much authentic because we are integral to this mathematical construct. We, and everything around us, are manifestations of countless information units,” he elaborated, intent on making his point clear. “If the essence of all existence is information, then ‘reality’ as we know it is solely a network of information. This insight sheds light on the nature of the Great Annihilation… However, explaining this fully would take us considerable time, time I believe you could use to figure

out on your own. The crucial concept here is that information never disappears; its ‘fundamental units’ merely undergo a state change…”

Pausing momentarily, Zhou Ming’s thought process visibly deepened, then with a determined gesture, he emphasized his next point.

“The ‘mathematical machine’ that underpins existence has always been operational, endlessly computing all possible ‘solutions’. Its constituent ‘parameters’ neither cease nor vanish; they merely undergo transformation —into states beyond our current capacity to perceive or interpret. Within the framework of this machine, these transitions remain part of the ongoing ‘calculations’. Yet, for us, beings who rely on deciphering these computations to comprehend our universe, this transformative phase… is what we see as the Great Annihilation.”

Chapter 805: About the Ashes

In a being where stars themselves seemed to roar with a sound so powerful it threatened to unravel the very fabric of existence, Ray Nora found herself immersed in a celestial revelation. Bathed in the dazzling light of countless stars, her soul felt illuminated, her mind appearing to dissolve under the weight of profound truths unveiled before her.

She felt an inexplicable unity with these truths, understanding the teachings of the thousand stars. Knowledge previously beyond her grasp now lay within her understanding, revealing the intricate logic that governed the cosmos. At the fringes of her vision, a mesmerizing pale purple starlight danced, its stunning beauty rendering her breathless.

Lifting her gaze to the heavens, where billions of starry eyes twinkled back at her, she whispered, half to herself, “I understand now… those are the remnants, the cooled embers left from when worlds collided… But the ashes aren’t extinguished; they merely await a new purpose, a reconfiguration…”

Her words sounded foreign, even to her, sparking a flicker of doubt. Yet, that doubt quickly dissipated as the meaning of her own words crystallized within her. The starlight in front of her seemed to flicker in agreement, acknowledging her realization.

Observing Ray Nora, Zhou Ming was taken aback by her precise understanding, especially since he didn’t expect the Frost Queen to grasp his concepts so deeply. His curiosity about her realization was

overshadowed by the urgency of focusing on the “ashes” beyond the boundaries that Ray Nora had identified.

He reflected on the theory posited by Navigator Two, that the universe could be viewed as a colossal “mathematical machine,” a repository and processor of all data and operational logic. The catastrophic event known as the Great Annihilation could then be interpreted as the result of forcing together several incompatible “systems,” leading to conflicts and critical errors.

This collision of cosmic systems disrupted the orderly flow of “information” within their domains, rendering what was once coherent and accessible data into chaos. The mathematical frameworks of these universes were compromised, losing their ability to function stably.

The protective measures erected by ancient gods resembled a makeshift sandbox environment, a last-ditch effort to maintain some semblance of order amid the chaos. This sandbox managed to preserve a fraction of the “information mapping,” yet, in essence, it too was engulfed in the systemic collapse.

Information, however, does not simply vanish, especially not in the face of cataclysms like the Great Annihilation. From the perspective of the “mathematical machine” model, the “information units” that make up the cosmos hadn’t disappeared; they had merely lost their linkage to the “world laws” or the operational framework of the universe, similar to…

Zhou Ming halted abruptly, his gaze drifting contemplatively towards the far corner of the room, where a lone computer sat humming quietly, its cursor blinking as though imbued with life. Under his watchful eye, the cursor began to move of its own accord, revealing a message on the screen:

“Data corrupted, format incomplete – World.”

For a brief moment, Zhou Ming blinked, and the message on the screen vanished as if it had been a mere figment of his imagination. Yet, the message resonated deeply with him, confirming his suspicions.

He exhaled softly, a whirlwind of thoughts swirling in his mind. As he began to sort through these thoughts, achieving a momentary clarity, a sense of unease crept back in.

Zhou Ming pondered the nature of the information — its apparent indestructibility within the confines of a “world” seemed logical, but what about beyond? In the vast emptiness, where the civilization of his creators had once caught fleeting glimpses of the boundless “void,” what universal laws might govern such a place?

The more he thought about it, the more he realized the futility of trying to comprehend what lay beyond his world with a mind that had never ventured past its borders. His brows furrowed in frustration, yet amidst this contemplation, he recalled his recent discussions with Navigator Two.

He remembered the AI’s fear and paranoia, its concerns and visions of transcending the very fabric of their world — leaving a “possibility” for future civilizations to explore.

Gradually, as his mind settled, a smile crept across Zhou Ming’s face. The mysteries that eluded him now would, he believed, one day be unraveled by someone in the future.

Observing the ancient being before her, Ray Nora sensed his turbulent thought process come to rest. Gathering her courage, she timidly inquired, “Do you have any plans next?”

Zhou Ming paused, lifting his hand to gaze silently at his palm.

There, the Bright Star began to dance, its light spreading across his skin, briefly bringing forth “ashes” that morphed into various forms before

dissipating like mirages.

He mused aloud, “The fundamental ‘material’ issue has been resolved, yet the nature of these materials isn’t quite as anticipated. These ‘cooled ashes’ have lost all connection to the world’s foundational system; they’ve ceased their evolution, setting them apart from the Four Gods and the Boundless Sea… A gentle ‘recompilation’ won’t suffice to reshape them. As you’ve seen, the moment my influence wanes, they simply fade away. These ‘cooled embers’ are devoid of the self-sustainability needed for permanence…”

“Perhaps the solution lies in reaching a ‘critical point’? We need to fundamentally restructure these ‘materials’ by redefining their relationships and providing them with an initial burst of momentum…”

Zhou Ming shared his thoughts aloud, seemingly indifferent to whether Ray Nora, known as “the Frost Queen,” could grasp the complexity of his ideas. Given her past reactions, which suggested a deep understanding of many topics, he treated her as someone with a keen intuitive grasp.

Ray Nora, who had become accustomed to the depth and intricacy of their conversations, effortlessly navigated the complexity of the discussion, grasping the concept he presented.

Her response came with a mix of surprise and concern, “Do you mean to ignite the entire Boundless Sea?” Her eyes widened at the thought, revealing her misinterpretation of his statement.

“No, no, no,” Zhou Ming hastened to clarify, with a dismissive wave of his hand. “The ‘critical point’ I’m referring to isn’t about causing a literal explosion of something specific. It’s more about a metaphorical ‘information explosion,’” he explained, attempting to correct her misunderstanding while pondering, “Though, it may indeed result in a significant release of energy, it’s not about destroying the Boundless Sea…”

He left unsaid the fact that the Boundless Sea might nevertheless be irretrievably altered or even disappear as a result of this process.

Ray Nora, still intrigued but choosing not to delve further into the fate of the Boundless Sea, shifted the conversation after a moment's thought, "Do you have an idea where this 'critical point' might be?"

Zhou Ming, stroking his chin thoughtfully, replied with careful consideration, "I have some preliminary thoughts," before quickly steering the topic away, "But there's no need for concern over this at the moment. My current priority is on those 'ashes' beyond the boundary."

This response brought a solemn expression to Ray Nora's face.

"The Vanished is navigating towards the world's end," Zhou Ming mused, hinting at a significant upcoming venture. "After this journey concludes, I must personally explore what lies beyond the boundary—to see those 'ashes' you mentioned with my own eyes."

Ray Nora, ready to assist, promptly asked, "Is there something I can do to help?"

"My physical presence is bound here… at least for now," Zhou Ming responded earnestly, "So, when the time comes, I'll need you to lead the Vanished to that specific area of ashes."

Confused, Ray Nora questioned, "What exactly should I do?"

"In practical terms, your direct involvement isn't necessary—it's actually your 'little house' that will play a crucial role," Zhou Ming explained, gesturing towards the window, "Position your 'little house' at the fog's edge, and Alice should manage to locate it."

"My house?" Ray Nora echoed, momentarily puzzled before realization dawned, "Oh, you're referring to its connection with 'Alice's Mansion'?"

With a slight nod, Zhou Ming confirmed her understanding.

The “room” that Ray Nora acquired from Alice’s Mansion is fundamentally the escape pod from the spaceship known as New Hope. Given its nature as an escape pod, it’s designed with features akin to emergency positioning and distress signaling capabilities. Zhou Ming had come across information deep within Alice’s Mansion indicating an “unauthorized ejection of the escape pod.” Logically, as the originating vessel, Alice’s Mansion—or more accurately, New Hope—should possess the technology to re-establish the location of this escape pod.

Suppose the mother ship can determine the pod’s location. In that case, Alice (who is Navigator Three, piloting the Vanished) should be capable of pinpointing Ray Nora’s precise position at the edge of their known universe.

Zhou Ming considers this strategy the most viable approach to navigate to the “lands beyond.” In a realm where conventional order disintegrates and the very fabric of space-time is in flux, specific methods of positioning and navigation are crucial. This is true even for the Vanished, a vessel tasked with traversing such chaotic boundaries.

However, Zhou Ming also contemplates potential complications—such as damage to the escape pod’s positioning system, Alice’s Mansion’s inability to locate it, or the unique conditions at the universe’s border distorting or obstructing the connection between the pod and the mother ship. Thus, before Ray Nora sets off, it’s essential to prepare alternative solutions.

Under Ray Nora’s inquisitive watch, Zhou Ming extended his hand, revealing a softly glowing pale green flame, enveloped in a celestial light, gently flickering in his palm.

“Accept this; it’s a far mightier flame than the one I’ve given you before,” he offered. “Should Alice fail to locate the ‘little house,’ I intend to use this

flame as a means to forge a path. Yet, consider this a contingency plan. The flame's ability to transmit power has its limits. Ideally, the Vanished should directly navigate to the designated location."

Ray Nora eyed the mesmerizing flame, its luminance steeped in starlight, casting a brilliant glow in the dimly lit chaos around them. The power emanating from the flame instilled a sense of awe and a touch of fear within her—a feeling she hadn't encountered even when braving the depths of the icy seas.

After a moment of hesitation, marked by the gravity of the task ahead, the queen gave a slight nod.

Extending her hand towards the flame, she affirmed, "I'll carry it with me—beyond the boundary, awaiting your arrival and that of the Vanished."

Chapter 806: Far from Home

Ray Nora departed, taking with her the symbolic flame that had been entrusted to her by Zhou Ming. She, the queen of travel, along with her unique drifting home, vanished into the boundless, murky fog visible from the window. It was a considerable time after her departure that Zhou Ming, still standing by the window, took a deep breath, detached himself from the view outside, and looked away.

Zhou Ming had always harbored a deep curiosity about the “Frost Queen” and her enigmatic ability to navigate through the thick, seemingly impenetrable fog that enveloped the world. He was particularly fascinated by the concept of the drifting house, which was essentially the escape pod from the New Hope, journeying through what was considered the edge of the world. Despite knowing its origin, he struggled to comprehend the nature of its power and how it managed to traverse the fog-laden unknown. Ray Nora, however, seemed incapable of providing a detailed explanation for this phenomenon.

When pressed by Zhou Ming about how she managed to “travel” with such ease, Ray Nora’s responses were vague, attributing it to a sort of “instinct.” She described herself and the drifting house as a unified entity, navigating the fog as if she were merely walking through it, unaffected by the spatial-temporal anomalies or the energy requirements that one might expect to consider in such a scenario.

Zhou Ming found her explanation almost mystical, concluding that the escape pod must have retained its complete automatic navigation system.

This system, transformed by the catastrophic events known as the Great Annihilation, could have evolved into what he termed a “supernatural characteristic” – akin to a “navigation instinct” that became apparent when Alice assumed control.

Regardless, the intricacies of how the “Vanished” was propelled through the fog at the world’s edge remained a mystery, yet this did not hinder its journey across the unknown…

Shifting his focus, Zhou Ming sighed lightly, clearing his mind of these ponderings, and approached his desk.

His desk was home to an LCD monitor, softly glowing, and a computer tower that hummed quietly, both appearing as conventional technological devices but functioning as usual, as if awaiting his command.

However, Zhou Ming did not engage with the keyboard or mouse before him. Instead, he sat quietly, his gaze fixed on the blinking cursor in the search box on the screen, reminiscent of a man confronting a reflection of his past self in a mirror.

After a moment of silence, he murmured, acknowledging the interconnectedness of his surroundings and himself, “You are part of this place, as is this desk. The floor, the roof, everything here is… and so am I. We all are, aren’t we?”

The cursor continued its steady blink, offering no response to Zhou Ming’s contemplation. Gradually, the light from the LCD screen began to fade, dimming to darkness until the screen resembled an empty mirror.

In this darkened mirror, Zhou Ming found himself staring back at his own reflection, a silent witness to his introspection.

At the periphery of his vision, Zhou Ming began to notice something extraordinary. On the surfaces of the seemingly mundane objects around

him—his desk, the walls, the ceiling, even the corner shelves and the modest wardrobe that had been fixtures of his home for countless years—a soft, pale purple starlight started to emerge and swell. This was not just any ordinary phenomenon; it was a signal, an almost uncontrollable transformation nearing its critical threshold.

Then, an unexpected itch on his arm drew Zhou Ming's attention downward, where he found the "World Tree" Atlantis, a tiny sapling, floating beside him. The small tree, with its branches tenderly brushing against his skin, seemed to convey a sense of unease.

Taking a brief moment to collect his thoughts, Zhou Ming gently lifted Atlantis, placing it on the desk with a delicate touch.

"Don't be afraid, little sapling, it's not time yet," he whispered soothingly to the top of Atlantis, his voice imbued with a calm reassurance. A faint smile graced his lips as he continued, "I will make sure everything is arranged perfectly. You'll be planted in fertile, stable ground where the sun shines bright and the wind caresses softly… Everyone will find their place there, Saslokha included…"

Now resting quietly on the desk, Atlantis seemed to respond with a soft rustling, as if it was whispering back, echoing Zhou Ming's promise with the sound of winds from distant memories sweeping through the World Tree's foliage.

Gradually, the encroaching starlight that had begun to infiltrate his room receded, and everything within his sight returned to its usual state.

"It's not time yet…" murmured the "Singularity" within the confines of the apartment, a hint of anticipation in its tone. "The day has yet to arrive…"

…

In another scene, Goathead suddenly raised its head, its deep, obsidian-like black eyes fixating on the figure who had just entered. For a fleeting moment, it seemed as if the entire cabin was bathed in diffused starlight, with a towering figure stepping through the Door of the Lost, radiating a power so immense it appeared capable of subduing the Vanished itself.

However, this illusion quickly vanished from Saslokha's sight, replaced by the more familiar scene of the captain entering his cabin, much like any other day.

"Duncan Abnomar," Duncan announced, raising his hand in greeting, cutting off any potential questions. "I've just returned from a 'long journey.'"

"…I almost didn't recognize you there for a moment," Goathead admitted, its tension easing as it began to ramble. "You've seemed quite… ominous after your recent outings. Sometimes, when you walk in, I'm not entirely sure what to expect… Ah, excuse my rambling. Don't take offense to my bluntness; the sight earlier had me a bit on edge. Are you alright? Do you need to rest? They haven't returned yet, but I expect them soon. Shirley's hunger should be well satiated by now, and we might be nearing our destination. Alice is still steering us…"

Goathead's rapid-fire chatter hit Duncan like a deluge just as he stepped back through the door, his heart tangled with complex emotions from his journey. Duncan, barely able to process the onslaught, could only respond with an instinctive and sharp retort: "Quiet!"

The first mate promptly snapped to silence, the abrupt "clack" marking the end of his outburst. After a brief pause, Goathead's demeanor softened, and with a sigh accompanied by a gentle smile, he offered a more subdued greeting: "…Welcome back, as long as you're alright."

Duncan let out a weary sigh as he moved toward the chart table, but not without giving Goathead a serious look and a nod of acknowledgment. “What could happen to me,” he said, his voice carrying a mixture of reassurance and introspection, “Don’t worry.”

His attention then shifted to the navigation chart, shrouded in a mist that seemed to erase all familiar landmarks. Beyond the world’s border, the chart’s once detailed depiction of the Boundless Sea’s routes and markers had been swallowed by an endless expanse of grey-white fog, with only the pale green lines indicating the Vanished’s own path faintly visible.

That ghostly trace on the chart showed they had traversed roughly half the distance to the world’s end, nearing what was labeled as the third node—this was the extent of guidance the chart could offer now.

Duncan found himself pondering whether the real Duncan Abnomar, the original captain who had dared to challenge the world’s border a century ago, had navigated with such a vague chart—or had he ventured forth without any chart at all?

Caught in these fleeting thoughts, Duncan’s attention was drawn by the cheerful sounds drifting in from the deck.

His crew had returned, their spirits high from their latest escapade aboard the Bright Star.

A surge of unnamed emotion rose within him, bringing a smile to his face. Duncan pushed away from the chart table and made his way to the door, stepping out to greet his returning crew.

Nina and Shirley, caught up in their playful antics on the deck, paused and turned at the sound of his approach. Nina’s face brightened with a beaming smile as she waved enthusiastically: “Uncle Duncan!”

Morris, momentarily pausing his pipe-smoking, removed the pipe from his lips and offered Duncan a respectful bow. Vanna greeted him with a warm smile and a nod. Shirley, perched atop Dog, laughed and flaunted a bit too proudly, “I ate a bit too much…” her gesture exaggerated yet endearing.

Nina, bubbling with laughter, approached Duncan carrying a lunchbox. “This is sweet pancakes and carrot stewed meat made by Luni. I’ll put it on the table for you, don’t forget to eat~” With these cheerful words, she briskly made her way past Duncan and into the captain’s cabin.

Duncan’s face remained lit with a gentle smile as he observed the vibrant scenes unfolding around him. His crew was alive with energy, engaging in conversation, laughter, playful jests, and occasional boasts. He watched sailors emerge from below deck, grumbling to Morris about the challenge of scrubbing “unidentifiable viscous substances” from the pots in the kitchen. Suddenly, Agatha materialized in the air, causing Shirley to make a run for it. However, her escape was short-lived as Dog, ever vigilant, gently tugged her back with the leash.

From a distance, Duncan silently observed these moments, as if attempting to etch each vibrant image and personality into his memory forever.

For him, this was undeniably the best day he had spent aboard this ship.

Then, his attention was drawn by a deep, resonant rumbling from above and a subtle tremor beneath his feet, signaling a shift. Outside, against the monotonous grey-white expanse that surrounded the Vanished, vibrant streaks of color abruptly sliced through the fog, heralding the end of their jump through the channel.

As the ghostly silhouette of the New Hope began to dissolve above them, the entrance to the jump channel started to disintegrate, unveiling a tapestry of grey, black, and dark red hues within the dense fog ahead. This visual

tumult was accompanied by the unmistakable sound of ships slicing through water – they had reached their destination.

“…Jump stop…”

This announcement, somewhat garbled and distant, floated to everyone’s ears, prompting a unified rush to the ship’s side to witness the new scene. Duncan’s gaze, however, was momentarily drawn away towards the stern deck. In the next instant, Alice’s head appeared, peeking over the railing of the driving platform, her face breaking into a joyful wave: “Captain! We’ve arrived! It’s the festival of fire…”

In an expected twist, her head detached, tumbling down and coming to a rest at Duncan’s feet after a few bounces.

Alice, looking slightly puzzled, glanced up at Duncan.

He let out a resigned sigh: “Sometimes, I wonder if you do it on purpose.”

After a moment of reflection, Alice responded: “Save, save, save…”

Chapter 807: The Island of Ashes

The colossal silhouettes of the Vanished and the Bright Star cut through the thick fog at the world's end, sailing into a calm sea that was materialized into existence, with their destination clearly visible ahead – it was right in front, a desolate land floating on the ocean, covered in ashes.

Apart from that particularly desolate piece of land, no other significant objects could be seen across the sea, only clusters of floating ash drifting atop the mirror-like water surface, casting shadows under the chaotic daylight, resembling… fallen clouds.

The immense silhouettes of the two ships emerged from the dense fog at the edge of the world, gliding into a sea that seemed to spring into existence just for them. Ahead lay their destination, a solitary, ash-covered landmass adrift in the ocean, stark and devoid of life.

Beyond this bleak island, the sea stretched empty and unmarked, save for the occasional clusters of floating ash that skittered across the still surface of the water, casting eerie shadows in the unpredictable light. These shadows, under the tumultuous sky, took on the semblance of clouds that had plummeted from the heavens.

Navigating a path carved by gatherings of ash, the Vanished made its slow approach toward the desolate island. The sea around the hull mirrored the sky above so perfectly that Duncan, for a moment, believed they were sailing through the air itself. The surrounding mist and ash swirled around the vessels, creating an illusion of floating through clouds, with denser patches of ash mimicking islands adrift in a celestial sea. As the Vanished

moved, it did not so much as ripple the water but rather gently coaxed the ash and fog to part before reassembling in its wake.

Shirley, leaning against the ship's railing with Dog by her side, was captivated by the seascape unfolding before them. Despite the numerous wonders they had encountered on their travels with the Vanished, she remained profoundly moved by the beauty they found at each new waypoint.

"Dog… I've been feeling lately that not having enough words is quite limiting," Shirley confessed quietly, her voice barely a whisper as though she feared being overheard by the captain, yet she chose not to communicate through their symbiotic mental link, perhaps wishing for someone else to overhear her reflections, "All I can think to say is 'wow,' but this place… it's truly magnificent."

"Do you want two more books?" Dog responded, his head tilting slightly, "Or perhaps you should start by finishing those books you've stashed under your bed?"

Caught off guard by the suggestion, Shirley quickly silenced Dog with a gentle push on his head, whispering, "Shh-"

Duncan, overhearing the exchange between Shirley and Dog, chose not to intervene, his attention wholly absorbed by the island now coming into clearer view. As they drew nearer, the stark details of the island became evident.

It was a flat, lifeless expanse, devoid of vegetation, not particularly large but significant as the final resting place for a "deity." Unlike the grandiose temple dedicated to the Leviathan Queen or the stunning crystalline burial sites of Navigator Two, this island boasted no structures or monuments. Only ashes, dust, and the occasional wisp of smoke marked its surface.

With a mix of emotions hard to articulate, Duncan directed the Vanished to anchor near the island's shore before taking a small boat to land on its ash-covered beach.

The landscape they encountered was a stark monument to the power of fire, with evidence of its retreat leaving behind a world of soft, warm ashes underfoot. Dark red scars streaked through the layer of ash, fading as if withdrawing with each passing moment.

As Duncan and his companions disembarked onto the island's expansive, ash-covered beach, they were met with the novel sensation of ash's soft warmth under their feet, making their way cautiously towards the island's heart.

The island offered no clear paths, just a blanket of fine ash covering everything in sight. The group moved with extra caution, mindful of the hidden obstacles beneath the ash – nobody was keen on stumbling and falling into the unknown qualities of the ash layer.

Shirley began to voice her discomfort only a short distance into their trek. "It feels like ash has filled my shoes… And it's all over my skirt too…" she complained, envisioning a thorough bath upon their return, "This ash finds its way into everything!"

Trailing behind, Lucretia offered her perspective, "This place must have once been consumed by intense flames for such a landscape to remain even after the fire has devoured all." Despite the ash-covered surroundings, Lucretia walked with an effortless grace, a beautiful sun umbrella in her hand creating a gentle breeze around her, repelling the ash. She gazed into the distance, noting, "There are still some smoke columns over there; not all flames have died, but for the rest of the island, those are merely the last embers."

Observing Lucretia’s unfazed poise, Nina couldn’t hide her admiration, “Magic is so convenient…”

“Envious? It’s the reward of countless nights spent over a century,” Lucretia responded with a smile, then glanced at Duncan, offering, “Do you need one? I have an extra umbrella – it’s quite effective at keeping you clean and making breathing easier.”

Duncan looked at the ash clinging to him and then at Lucretia’s almost magical purple sun umbrella, his skepticism clear. “No need,” he declined.

“I could change it to black,” Lucretia suggested earnestly, “And if you like, I could even add a skull motif to the handle.”

Before Duncan could respond, Shirley briefly entertained the thought of the captain with a dark, gothic-style umbrella, a mental image so incongruous it took her by surprise.

Duncan faced Lucretia with a determined expression, and then, without a word, flames engulfed his body. He transformed into a spectral figure within the flames, levitating above the ash-covered ground, and declared, “I have my own way.”

Lucretia, watching, allowed a small, secretive smile to play at the corners of her mouth, unseen by her father. Then, struck by sudden inspiration, Shirley excitedly slapped her hand, exclaiming, “Oh, right, I think I have my own way too…”

Before Shirley could finish her sentence, a cacophony of crackling sounds erupted from within her, quickly followed by a dense shroud of dark smoke that enveloped her completely. Sinister, jagged shards of bone began to emerge and extend from her frame. Within moments, she had transformed into an imposing, shadowy demonic figure. Then, with the aid of twelve

skeletal limbs that extended from her back, she lifted herself above the ground, moving effortlessly over the ash-covered terrain.

“This is much more comfortable, and the view from up here isn’t half bad either,” came Shirley’s voice, now deeper and tinged with a mature huskiness. She casually stirred a mound of ash on the ground with the tip of one elongated limb, her tone reflective, “…I don’t know why, but there’s something about these ashes that unsettles me. It’s not merely their filthiness; there’s an odd, unnerving sensation they produce… it’s quite disagreeable when they adhere to my form.”

Upon hearing Shirley’s contemplative murmurs, Nina, who was walking alongside Duncan, expressed her agreement with a grimace and a tug at Duncan’s sleeve, “I feel exactly the same. There’s something about these ashes that’s just… suffocating. It feels like I’m being smothered, restricted in movement, as though they’re wrapping themselves around me, making it hard to breathe.”

Duncan halted in his tracks at this, his demeanor shifting from amused interest in Shirley’s transformation to concern. “Is everyone feeling this way?” he inquired, turning to gauge the reactions of their companions.

“Not at all,” replied Alice quickly, the mechanical doll examining her own form and articulating her joints. “I’m just noticing the ashes seeping into my joints, causing a bit of irritation. A thorough cleaning is definitely in order after we return.”

“I share Shirley and Nina’s sentiments,” Morris chimed in seriously. “There’s an unsettling essence about this place… It’s unlike the domains of the Storm Goddess or the God of Wisdom. It feels as though something buried within these ashes is ‘stirring,’ exerting an influence on us.”

He paused, seemingly to consider his next words carefully, then added, “However, I don’t detect any overt hostility. It appears more to be a

characteristic of the ‘environment’ here than anything else.”

Hearing the varied responses, Duncan’s expression grew concerned. He then called out in another direction, “Vanna, what’s your take on this?”

Silence followed. The endless sea of ashes before them offered no reply, though Duncan was sure Vanna had been there just a moment ago. He could have sworn he saw her silhouette flicker and then disappear as if she had been silently observing until just now.

An unsettling quiet descended upon the group, with Nina staring bewilderedly towards where Vanna had been, the question of Vanna’s identity barely forming in her mind.

However, before she could fully grasp the thought, a sudden burst of flames interrupted her contemplation. A deluge of memories and information rushed back into her awareness as if breaking through a dam of forgetfulness –

Vanna, the youngest inquisitor from Pland… renowned for her formidable prowess and steadfast faith… her striking silver hair… initially reserved upon joining the ship but soon revealed a cheerful, optimistic nature… known for her lighthearted complaints about matrimonial prospects… notably tall…

Nina, her mind a whirlwind of confusion, lifted her gaze as countless fragments of memory swirled and merged within her consciousness, forming fleeting images of Vanna that quickly dissolved into indistinct shapes. She perceived the gentle caress of invisible winds traversing the island, stirring the ash into the air. Amidst this ghostly dance, a tall silhouette seemed to stride toward the island’s heart, moving as if in another realm entirely, its back turned, resembling a wanderer who had relinquished all memories, embarking on an endless voyage.

Snapped out of her reverie by this vision, Nina pointed excitedly towards the fading figure amidst the wind-whipped ashes, exclaiming, “There! Vanna went in that direction! I just saw her moving there!”

Her alert seemed to rouse everyone from their daze, prompting exchanged glances filled with uncertainty. The fleeting images of Vanna and the spectral appearances in the wind momentarily blurred the line between reality and illusion, leaving them all grappling with their perceptions. It was at this moment of collective disorientation that the captain’s steady, commanding voice cut through the confusion, pulling them back from the brink of oblivion –

“Everyone, back to the ship!”

Emerald flames flared to life, carving out a sanctuary amidst the ash-strewn wasteland. Morris observed as a fiery vortex materialized next to Duncan, with the silhouette of Ai floating above this fiery gateway.

“These ashes are the remnants of a forgotten history,” Duncan announced urgently, “Return to the ship now.”

Nina, driven by concern, couldn’t help but ask, “What about you?”

“…I need to retrieve Vanna,” Duncan declared, his gaze fixed on the endless expanse of ashes that seemed to stretch into infinity, “And while I’m out there, I’ll also look for Ta Ruijin.”

Chapter 808: The Invisible City

Vanna had been journeying along this path for an extensive period – so extensive, in fact, that the origins of her voyage had faded from her memory. She couldn't recall when it began or the reasons that propelled her into this seemingly perpetual quest. The starting point of her journey, as well as its purpose, had slipped from her grasp.

Her world was a wasteland. Throughout her travels, she encountered nothing but vast expanses of yellow sand that stretched into the horizon, the crumbling remains of once-great cities on the verge of collapse, and ancient artifacts shrouded in layers of dust. She wandered through these abandoned ruins, her steps retracing the echoes of a forgotten era. Occasionally, she would halt at these sites, though any details she observed would evaporate from her memory by dawn's light; she retained only a vague impression of having passed dilapidated walls.

The wind, a relentless force, carried the sand across the desert, creating a symphony of sharp, eerie sounds as it clashed with the rocks. These sounds, reminiscent of spectral wails, were a constant backdrop to her journey. Amidst this cacophony, Vanna discerned a distinct noise, one that had become a familiar presence on her travels:

"Ding… Ding… Ding…"

It was reminiscent of the sound of metal against stone, akin to the rhythmic beating heard in a blacksmith's workshop.

Upon hearing this, Vanna halted her march on the sandy path, peering into the distance with narrowed eyes. She had come to associate this metallic chorus with the proximity of new ruins or hidden artifacts.

Yet, the origin of these sounds and their connection to the discoveries remained a mystery to her.

Suddenly, against the endless curtain of yellow sand, the vague outline of a structure materialized, similar to other remnants she had stumbled upon during her journey.

Vanna observed this newly revealed cluster of buildings briefly, a sense of familiarity enveloping her despite her initial surprise. After a momentary pause, she resumed her walk, advancing towards the edifice amidst the swirling chaos of wind and sand.

Just then, a young woman’s voice pierced the solitude: “Where did you come from?”

Startled, Vanna scanned her surroundings, but her eyes met only the swirling dance of yellow grains. The source of the voice seemed devoid of any physical presence as if it were a mere figment of her imagination.

Puzzled and with a sense that the sand was clouding her thoughts, she shook her head, determined to press on.

The voice persisted, this time with a hint of curiosity: “Why aren’t you responding to me?”

Accompanying the voice, Vanna thought she could detect the sound of footsteps, mirroring her own yet eerily close.

Halting once more, she fixed her gaze on the empty space beside her. Though the speaker remained invisible, Vanna felt the subtle presence of someone, or something, an “aura” of sorts, near her.

Could it be that an unseen companion was journeying alongside her, attempting to engage in conversation?

This occurrence prompted a cascade of questions in her mind. Was such a phenomenon commonplace in this desolate world? Did an invisible entity truly exist, sharing this vast emptiness with her?

As Vanna's thoughts once again became muddled, a whirlwind of absurd and strange ideas surged through her mind, only to dissipate as swiftly as they had appeared. She paused briefly, wrestling with her confusion, before she cautiously broke the silence, "I don't remember where I came from."

"Forgot where you came from?" The voice of her unseen companion floated through the air again, this time with a hint of cheerfulness, "Ah, that's unfortunate. Forgetting your origins can make it difficult to find your way back… But it's not a rare occurrence here."

"Here? Not rare?" Vanna replied, her voice tinged with surprise, "Are there others like me here?"

"Yes, many," the voice responded, its tone suggesting a smile, "Over there, in that city, it's bustling with people."

Without seeing where the voice pointed, Vanna naturally turned her gaze toward the indistinct outlines of buildings that loomed in the sandstorm, her curiosity piqued: "In that city…"

"Yes, in that city," the voice reiterated enthusiastically, "People have arrived here from every conceivable direction. Some retain a vague memory of their origins, while others have even forgotten their own names. But such details lose their significance on this journey, which spans from one distant place to another. Sometimes you pause briefly, and at other times, you find yourself unable to go any further – and wherever you find yourself stuck,

that place becomes your new point of reference… Yeah, my brother once shared that insight with me."

Vanna, still perplexed, took a step towards the shadowy cluster of buildings. Almost instantly, she heard the sound of footsteps accompanying her own, a gentle reminder of the unseen presence trailing behind her.

"Your brother?" Vanna inquired, the oddity of speaking to an invisible being slowly fading, replaced by a sense of normalcy. After all, having a companion to converse with during such a lengthy trek seemed like a rare comfort.

"Yes, my brother. He's six years older than me," the unseen voice replied promptly, its tone still carrying a cheerful lilt. "But it's been many years since I last saw him. He left for Vesseran to pursue his studies, and we've lost contact ever since."

Vesseran? The name echoed in Vanna's mind, stirring a flicker of recognition. Was Vesseran a city, perhaps?

"Do you worry about him?" she found herself asking.

"Not really," came the response from beside her, "Many of us haven't had news from the outside world in a long time, nor have we been able to send any messages out. Being out of touch isn't necessarily a bad thing…"

The voice seemed to drift off, carried away by the wind, which then became distorted as if stretching across a vast distance before being swallowed up by a cacophony of noises. Vanna strained to understand the last few words, but they were lost to her, leaving only silence in their wake.

She stood motionless for a few moments, the absence of the voice leaving a void. Breaking the silence, she called out, "Are you still there?"

But the desert offered no reply, save for its characteristic eerie howls and the intermittent sound of metal clinking, resonating through the air like an

unanswered question.

It appeared as though her unseen companion had disappeared, swept away by the desert winds.

After some time had passed, Vanna collected her thoughts and resumed her trek toward the city that lay in the distance.

Her journey was long and arduous, but just as the day began to transition into evening, she reached her destination. The “city” her companion had described was in sight. But contrary to what she might have hoped for, there were no signs of life or the hustle and bustle of city inhabitants. Instead, what greeted her were the ruins of a city long forsaken, its walls and buildings surrendered to the encroaching sands, left to erode in the relentless passage of time.

Upon finding what appeared to be the remnants of a gate amidst the crumbling city walls, Vanna peered through, taking in the desolate view of the city’s ruins before advancing toward the “city.”

Yet, just as she was about to cross the threshold of the “gate,” a firm and commanding voice emerged from nowhere: “Stop, stranger – where do you come from?”

Startled, Vanna paused.

Could it be that an invisible soldier was guarding this derelict gateway?

She had navigated through cultist-infested sewers, faced down creatures that lurked in the shadows, but she had never found herself in such a peculiar situation.

Hesitantly, she turned towards the source of the voice, opting to respond as though this were a normal interaction: “I’m… on a journey, but I can’t recall my point of origin.”

Recalling her invisible travel companion's earlier words about the "city" being populated with many "residents" who had similarly lost their bearings, Vanna hoped her answer wouldn't raise any eyebrows.

The "guard" remained silent for a moment, possibly contemplating her response or maybe disappearing into the whirl of the sandstorm. Vanna waited, a blend of patience and curiosity holding her in place, and just when she was about to proceed regardless, a voice filled with warmth and familiarity spoke from beside her –

"Ah, you've arrived!"

It was the voice of her previous missing "invisible travel companion."

"I was worried you might have gotten lost," the voice expressed cheerfully. "The journey here is fraught with diverging paths, particularly those minor trails through the forest. Should the berry bushes beside the path catch your eye and lead you astray, you might spend an entire day finding your way back…"

Forests? Trails? Berry bushes?

As she listened to the continuing voice, Vanna's gaze swept back over her path – a landscape dominated by sand and stone, devoid of any forest or berry bush. What were these fantastical things doing in their conversation?

And as she stood there, bewildered, the authoritative voice of the guard spoke again, this time addressing the "invisible travel companion": "Is this your friend?"

"Yes, we encountered each other along the way," the youthful voice quickly responded. "She's traveled from afar, a newcomer to this place, unfamiliar with our ways. I thought I'd show her around the city."

"…Then you may enter, but be cautious not to stray. The evening approaches, and the wilderness beyond the city limits is fraught with

dangers, especially as darkness descends upon the forests."

"Ah! Thank you!"

The voice, brimming with enthusiasm, expressed gratitude towards the guard before addressing Vanna, "We're allowed to proceed now."

Redirecting her attention away from the desolate landscape that lay beyond the city's boundaries, Vanna acknowledged the guidance with a nod, orienting herself towards the source of the voice: "Understood."

She ventured into the so-called "thriving city," her steps taking her down a broad yet desolate avenue that ran straight from the city's entrance. The road was flanked by ruins, with yellow sand swallowing the remnants of what might once have been bustling streets and broken stone slabs scattered chaotically underfoot. From time to time, she caught the fleeting sounds of what could be mistaken for vendors peddling their wares, snippets of conversation, and the clatter of wheels against cobblestones. However, these auditory glimpses quickly vanished into the wind, leaving her unable to discern any distinct words or phrases.

"How do you find it? Quite lively, isn't it?" The young and vibrant voice emerged beside Vanna, almost as if gesturing towards imaginary storefronts and the hustle of unseen crowds, "I've called this place home for many years. It's the most bustling city in the entire continent."

…The continent? What is that?

A wave of disorientation momentarily swept over Vanna as if a surge of knowledge, alien to her understanding of the world, sought entry into her consciousness, vying for a foothold in her mind.

But in the next instant, her resolve steeled, dispelling the burgeoning confusion and repelling the intrusive knowledge that attempted to take root.

Chapter 809: Ashes with the Wind

Vanna advanced with caution in the abandoned metropolis, now a ghost town devoid of life. Beside her, an unseen companion kept pace, eagerly describing the vibrance and beauty that once characterized this thriving city. It was painted as a bustling hub of activity, its streets teeming with the joyful hustle and bustle of daily life.

This city was once the crown jewel of the entire continent, a place renowned far and wide. It served as a home for many and a waypoint for travelers from all corners of the globe. The city's guards were known for their unwavering vigilance, its inhabitants for their warmth and generosity. It was a melting pot where new and exciting merchandise, innovative ideas, and captivating stories from across the world converged.

"You're going to love it here, just like everyone else does," the invisible guide assured Vanna with a buoyant tone. "Give it a few days, and you'll be captivated by its charm!"

While Vanna half-heartedly absorbed her guide's spirited narrative, her thoughts veered towards the peculiar. Despite the apparent absence of residents, she occasionally caught snippets of conversation, suggesting she wasn't alone. She wondered how she was perceived by these unseen denizens. Did they view her as a blind swordsman, aimlessly wandering their streets with a weapon in hand? Was there no concern or curiosity from these invisible onlookers about her armed presence?

Her musings then shifted to her jovial guide, whose youthful voice suggested she was a young girl, invisible and intangible, making it

challenging for Vanna to rely on her for navigation. Instead, Vanna had been making her way through the decrepit ruins and crumbled walls based on her own decisions, indifferent to whether her guide could keep up or even followed. Yet, the guide seemed not to mind, remaining ever-present and engaging as though this were a prearranged outing for Vanna, her “new friend.”

Pausing at an intersection, Vanna took a moment to gather her thoughts, pondering her place in this unseen city and her relationship with her invisible guide.

Just as she grappled with these questions, a sudden wave of dizziness overcame her, more intense than before, leaving her mind momentarily blank, as if a crucial memory had slipped away.

Looking around at the desolate ruins with confusion, Vanna noticed that the earlier sense of something being amiss had now inexplicably faded away.

“Would you like some fruit?” A new voice, gentle and reminiscent of an elderly woman, broke the silence, offering refreshment as if from a roadside vendor. “They’re fresh from this morning, perfect for quenching your thirst after a long journey, aren’t they?”

Turning towards the source of the voice, Vanna saw nothing but a pile of wood and stones, partly concealed by the desert’s encroaching sands, and a fleeting shadow among the ruins, gesturing as if presenting goods for sale. A gust of wind blew, sweeping sand from the shadow’s hand, revealing nothing but an empty plank in front of it.

In the blink of an eye, the shadow vanished, leaving Vanna to contemplate the eerie and enigmatic nature of the deserted city.

Standing isolated at the crossroads, Vanna was engulfed in the eerie silence, the only sound being the hollow whispering of the wind. It dawned on her

that the voice of her “invisible companion” had ceased, leaving her in a prolonged silence.

Turning towards where she last felt the presence of her unseen guide, Vanna tentatively called out, “Are you still there?”

But no reply came.

The wind picked up slightly, dislodging a few grains of sand from a crumbling wall nearby. As they fell, they seemed to carry a faint yet distinct sound with them – a soft tinkling, reminiscent of a distant bell: ding, ding-ding…

With a fluid motion, Vanna shifted her great sword to her left hand and with her right, she drew a familiar symbol across her chest. The meaning of the symbol eluded her, but her body remembered the gesture as if it were a deeply ingrained habit, perhaps some sort of benediction.

With renewed caution, she gripped her sword firmly and ventured further into the heart of the city.

As she roamed the desolate ruins, it became clear that the city’s once sprawling and intricate streets were now endless vistas of yellow sand. The remains of buildings and pathways, although shattered and buried, hinted at their former splendor.

A thought struck Vanna – could this truly have been the world’s most vibrant and thriving metropolis? She pondered the countless lives that must have filled this vast city, the endless caravans bringing goods and stories from distant lands.

Yet, it now lay forsaken.

What had led to such a bustling city being deserted? When had it happened? And why, after all, had she come here?

Continuing her journey, Vanna’s train of thought was abruptly interrupted as she approached a particular building. The wind carried strange noises and, with it, a piece of paper swirling through the air, catching her attention with its barely visible writing.

Intrigued by the notion of paper surviving the relentless sandstorms, Vanna acted instinctively, catching the flying scrap. Upon inspection, she realized it was a fragment of a newspaper. The top half, though tattered, proudly displayed the newspaper’s name, while the bottom half bore text that had been worn away by time. Amidst the fading words, Vanna discerned a sentence that remained legible:

“…A great fire broke out in Pland, spreading from the upper to the lower district, damaging many factories and blocks, with casualties among the residents…”

Staring at the aged text, Vanna was enveloped in confusion. After a moment of contemplation, she finally articulated her bewilderment:

“What is Pland?”

No sooner had she spoken than the piece of newspaper in her grasp began to disintegrate, turning into yellow sand and slipping through her fingers, carried away by the wind.

Vanna paused, taking a moment to shake the last remnants of sand from her hand before she continued on her way.

Her journey through the ruins extended for what seemed like an eternity until she abruptly came to a halt before a peculiar structure. Amidst the swirling dust, the building appeared almost out of nowhere, its form rising awkwardly yet distinctly from the surrounding debris and fallen structures. It stood there, an anomaly among ruins, resembling a silent behemoth that had been quietly observing Vanna’s approach.

The structure was a modest-sized chapel, characterized by several spires that, while not grandiose, lent it an air of solemn dignity.

It was clear that the chapel had been abandoned; its exterior walls were discolored and cracked, its windows broken and scattered, and its roof tiles missing, all signs of long-term neglect. However, in stark contrast to the completely collapsed buildings that were engulfed by the encroaching sand, this chapel retained its basic structure. But what truly captured Vanna's attention was the small flowerbed situated at the chapel's entrance.

This flowerbed, though dilapidated and home only to dead plants, was remarkably free of sand, a curious sight in a land where the yellow desert sands seemed to invade every nook and cranny. It was as though someone, somewhere, was still tending to this broken garden and its desiccated flora.

Vanna stood before the flowerbed, her gaze lifting from the withered plants to the small, forlorn chapel. After a moment's contemplation, she stepped inside.

Crossing the threshold, she experienced a sudden shift in atmosphere; the pervasive, scorching heat of the desert was abruptly replaced by a cooler, more isolated environment. Then, almost immediately, she was greeted by a series of bright lights.

Despite its outwardly abandoned appearance, the interior of the chapel was surprisingly well-kept. The doors and windows remained intact, and the main hall was illuminated by bright, welcoming lights. Empty wooden pews were lined up in neat rows, leading to a pulpit that was softly lit from above, giving the chapel an air of sanctity and peace.

A wave of vague familiarity washed over Vanna. It was as if she had encountered this place before, either in person or through the words of another, yet she could not pinpoint the memory. Her life before entering this

vast, endless desert seemed like a distant dream, details blurred and unreachable.

Clutching her great sword, Vanna walked down the central aisle, surveying her surroundings with a mix of wariness and wonder. Eventually, she decided to take a moment to rest, choosing a bench near the front.

As she sat down, the ancient wood creaked under her weight, mirroring the stiffness and fatigue she felt in her own body. She sighed deeply, a tangible expression of her weariness.

Then, in the midst of the chapel's silence, a soft, almost imperceptible sound caught her attention. It was the sound of breathing.

Someone was sitting beside her.

Vanna turned her head sharply towards the source of the sound.

There, right beside her, was a young nun clad in a somber black habit, her age mirroring Vanna's. She sat in quiet contemplation, her head bowed in what appeared to be deep, devout prayer.

A real, tangible person!

The realization struck Vanna with the force of a revelation. It had been so long since she last encountered another living soul that the memory of human company had almost faded into the realm of myth. Her journey had felt eternal, a solitary trek through landscapes dominated by sand and shadow, accompanied only by elusive sounds and the ghost of her invisible guide. She had almost resigned herself to the belief that this desolate world was her sole domain, and she, its lone wanderer. But now, the sight of another human being sparked a flurry of emotions within her: excitement, confusion, and an inexplicable sense of recognition.

Vanna was on the verge of speaking, her mind racing with questions and a yearning for connection, "You are…"

“You’ve stayed here too long, sister,” the young nun interrupted, her voice serene yet carrying an undercurrent of solemnity. She raised her head, her gaze meeting Vanna’s with a calm intensity. “Ashes, it’s easy to be assimilated by the ashes.”

Chapter 810: The Erosion of Wind and Sand

The unsettling declaration from the young nun, “Ashes… can easily be assimilated by ashes…” brought Vanna to a momentary standstill. In that fleeting moment, a sensation washed over her as if a tight knot in her mind had slightly unraveled. She was on the verge of inquiring further when the nun, cloaked in black, allowed a soft smile to grace her lips. Then, to Vanna’s utter astonishment, the nun disintegrated into a heap of ashes that the wind whimsically scattered right before her eyes.

The sound of tapping, reminiscent of a familiar yet elusive memory, echoed once more from the void, signaling another presence within the church’s ancient walls. Vanna’s instincts sharpened; she turned her gaze towards the source, only to be met with the sight of an indistinct silhouette at the church’s entrance.

As the figure drew nearer, its form gradually became more defined with each advancing step. It was an elderly priest, his posture bent, adorned in the worn vestments of his vocation.

In one hand, the old priest held a lamp emitting a soft glow, its light reflecting off his hand, revealing a metallic sheen. It became apparent that he had lost an arm in some bygone conflict, now replaced with a steam-powered prosthetic. Despite his slow approach, his eyes never once settled on Vanna; instead, they were fixated on some distant point beyond her, filled with an ineffable longing.

Overcome with an inexplicable sense of recognition, Vanna felt compelled to leave her seat and greet this mysterious figure. “Hello, may I inquire as to where I am?” she ventured.

The priest halted, his attention still diverted beyond her, and responded in a tranquil tone, “You have strayed into an wayward thread of history, Inquisitor – you must find your exit from this place lest you too are reduced to ashes… He is no longer capable of discerning.”

Confusion laced Vanna’s voice as she asked, “He can no longer discern? Who are you referring to?”

“The deity tasked with the chronicling of history…” the old priest murmured. As his words trailed off, his body began to crumble into ashes, which the wind swiftly carried away. His parting words, barely audible, lingered in the air, “…everything… will drift towards the ultimate chaos…”

Warmed by an unseen force, a strand of ash brushed against Vanna’s fingertips, jolting her with its touch. Though her memory remained shrouded in mystery, unable to recall her past or recognize this desolate place, a deep-rooted alarm within her urged her to flee.

Without hesitation, she sprinted towards the main door of the church.

Pushing the door ajar, Vanna was greeted by the expansive night sky. Unbeknownst to her, day had transitioned to night, and the desert now lay under the cloak of darkness. The day’s blistering heat had succumbed to the chilly nocturnal winds, now reigning supreme over the barren landscape. The wind, a harbinger of the desert’s merciless nature, hurled sand like tiny daggers, lashing against the ancient ruins and Vanna’s exposed skin, inflicting a stinging pain.

Vanna’s skin, known for its resilience against small-caliber bullets, now bore the delicate lacerations inflicted by the sand, driven by the fierce wind.

She observed her arms with a mix of surprise and confusion; rather than blood, what seeped out from these fine wounds was akin to fine ashes, resembling black smoke that gently rose and then dissipated into the atmosphere as though being eagerly consumed by the very essence of this world.

The realization hit her – she was gradually being “absorbed” into the fabric of this strange world.

A fleeting thought urged her to seek refuge back within the church’s walls, yet the echo of the unnamed nun’s and the old priest’s forewarnings ignited a stark admonition within her heart.

The sanctuary, with its deceptive offer of shelter, posed a far greater peril than the abrasive desert sands. The illusion of safety within its confines threatened to erode her resolve, effectively disintegrating her existence into nothingness.

Determined, she knew she had to escape this city… These “ruins” that rose amidst the desert sands offered no shield; rather, they stood as beacons of danger. The environment here was paradoxical; the open, barren sands might paradoxically offer a safer passage…

These thoughts cascaded through her mind in a rapid torrent, yet her resolve did not waver. Protecting herself with a ragged cloak against the stinging assault of the sands, she made her way towards what she recalled as the city’s exit.

The sands around her stirred, hinting at a disturbance or, perhaps, revealing that this city had never truly permitted anyone to leave. Out of the corner of her eye, Vanna noticed a sudden movement in the sand. In an instant, a hand emerged, grasping her ankle with unexpected strength.

From the depths of the desert floor, a figure composed entirely of sand rose, gripping Vanna in a manner reminiscent of a soulless specter. It slithered on the ground, its visage ever-changing, momentarily taking shape only to release a series of garbled roars and murmurs!

Yet, this sandy assailant could not detain Vanna. With a determined step, she broke free from the grasp of the “sand person,” then forcefully stamped the ground, causing a thunderous noise. The resultant shockwave obliterated the sandy figure, scattering it into a cloud of dust around her.

As the dust settled, a half-buried stone pillar with faint inscriptions became visible among the sands: “…Wilhelm… The Black Sun descends from… we have failed…”

The moment of shock was fleeting, and Vanna, without a second’s pause, continued her flight.

The wind crescendoed into a howl, carrying with it a cacophony of sounds. These sounds, vague and overlapping, resembled the bustling noise of a busy marketplace, complete with the chatter of vendors, the footsteps of pedestrians, and the clatter of carriages.

Amidst the ruins of the sand city under the cloak of night, these vibrant sounds enveloped Vanna as if an invisible, bustling city had awakened beside her. She could almost visualize a lively and prosperous scene unfolding in parallel to her solitary escape, imagining a city that throbbed with life even under the cover of darkness. Meanwhile, from the corner of her eye, she noticed flickers of light emerging in the distance.

In this surreal tableau, it seemed as though, following its abandonment or perhaps its complete fading from collective memory, the city’s lights stubbornly persisted, lingering in the annals of history. These lights, relics of a bygone era, would dutifully flicker to life at dusk, casting their glow upon the spots they once brightened…

As darkness enveloped the city, the lights brought an eerie semblance of life to the ruins. Beams cut through the shadows, illuminating the skeletal remains of structures and fallen columns, around which shadowy figures moved, their voices a muffled cacophony in the dim light.

Vanna, sword in hand, moved through these spectral images with a single-minded focus. She navigated the illusion-filled landscape, her steps unwavering and determined, her eyes fixed on the path ahead.

Yet, despite her resolve, her body continued to succumb to the insidious assimilation by the surrounding invisible ashes. Her injuries multiplied, and even without the abrasive touch of the sand, her flesh seemed to fissure spontaneously, emitting plumes of black smoke and ash. With each puff of ash that left her body, the ambient sounds grew louder, the ghostly scenes around her clearer.

In one lucid moment, amidst the ambient noise, she caught snippets of conversation as if the speakers were right beside her, perhaps even addressing her:

“Have you heard? The Thirteen Islands of Witherland have vanished… Word from the north came just days ago… That fearsome ship tore open a portal to subspace…”

Vanna chose to ignore these disembodied voices. With a sweep of her arm, she conjured a gust that scattered the encroaching sand. Amidst this disturbance, a flyer whipped past her, carrying the unmistakable image of Tyrian Abnomar on a wanted poster. The figure beneath the portrait was a sequence of zeros so lengthy, it bordered on absurd, suggesting not a monetary reward but rather the immeasurable danger this individual posed.

Suddenly, the tranquility of the night was pierced by the sound of rhythmic music, suggesting the presence of a large gathering somewhere in the distance. Vanna strained to listen as voices cut through the murkiness:

“…A new queen for Frost… Today marks the coronation of Her Majesty Ray Nora. May we revel in the queen’s glory, seek her protection, and offer her our unwavering allegiance…”

This auditory chaos was soon joined by a plethora of sounds, sights, and snippets of information that seemed to envelop Vanna purposefully:

One street over buzzed with the celebration of Queen Ray Nora of Frost’s coronation day; another echoed with the turmoil of the Frostbite Rebellion; conversations about the wanted poster of the infamous former Frost Admiral Tyrian filled the air; and not too far off, a gathering around a podium where relics from the era of the ancient city-states were on display, with a prominent historian—credited with significant discoveries from that period—addressing the crowd. This figure, a beacon of knowledge in the field, was unfamiliar to Vanna…

Suddenly, as if conjured by the swirling winds and shifting sands before her, a figure materialized. He was a man dressed in worn, ragged garments, his movements betraying a sense of disorientation. His eyes, clouded with confusion, seemed to scan the horizon endlessly, as though trying to make sense of his surroundings. Clutched in his hands were a battered scroll and a stub of a pencil, and he stood there, his demeanor one of apprehension, as if the very air around him was a source of fear.

He bowed repeatedly to the invisible throngs that passed him by, his actions mimicking those of someone desperately seeking information from any who would listen. His mutterings were punctuated by moments of loud exclamations as though frustration had seized him in a sudden frenzy.

Vanna brushed past this enigmatic figure initially without a second thought, but a specific phrase uttered by the man halted her in her tracks. He was earnestly questioning the passersby, his voice tinged with urgency, “Excuse me… what year is it exactly? Does anyone know what year it is now?”

Turning her attention fully towards the man, Vanna noticed that he, too, seemed to recognize her presence, lifting his gaze to meet hers almost simultaneously.

“Hello, my name is Puman,” he introduced himself with a wave despite his evident confusion and wild-eyed appearance. His tone, oddly enough, retained a semblance of politeness, “I’m dreaming again, but this time I can’t seem to find the way out… Can you tell me what year it is now?”

Puman… could this truly be the infamous “mad poet” Puman, known more for his bewildering verses than clarity of mind?

Caught off guard by the encounter, Vanna barely had time to process the moment before the man, who had just identified himself as “Puman,” dissolved into the wind and sand as swiftly as he had appeared.

Left behind, as tangible proof of his brief presence, were the crumpled scroll and the pencil stub he had been clutching, now lying forsaken on the ground.

Chapter 811: At the End of the Wind and Sand

According to historical accounts, Puman, known centuries ago as the “Mad Poet,” was a unique individual who dared to delve into truths deemed forbidden and miraculously managed to survive. The legends tell of this poet’s peculiar habit of sinking into dreamlike states, during which he professed to journey through various era and worlds, each more bizarre than the last.

Puman’s legacy is a vast collection of writings that have left subsequent generations in awe. From the onset of his career, his work displayed a remarkable blend of elegance and depth, captivating even the most discerning critics from various city-states with his sophisticated yet profound poetry. However, as Puman approached the twilight of his life, a discernible shift occurred in his creations. His later poems began to explore themes that were at once bizarre and chilling, replete with disconcerting metaphors and ramblings reminiscent of a prophet’s frenzied declarations. He became obsessed with conveying to humanity the existence of entities and realms beyond the scope of known reality, his writings bordering on the sacrilegious. Consequently, Puman transformed into a figure shrouded in despair and fear.

The admiration and praise that once flowed freely towards him eventually turned into aversion and apprehension. Admirers who had once held him in high esteem now regarded him as a menace. Even the church’s authorities

attempted to curb his influence, though they failed to identify any tangible corrupt or blasphemous essence in his writings.

Puman's final days remain shrouded in mystery, adding another layer to his enigmatic legacy. Some narratives suggest he was confined by the church, ultimately meeting a quiet end in an asylum on a desolate island. Yet, there are accounts that insist he continued to live, with claims of sightings as late as the winter of 1842, where witnesses described seeing the poet, unmistakable as depicted in portraits, standing on a frost-laden cliff, pen and paper in hand, composing his verses.

A "caretaker," purporting to have been by Puman's side during his last years, offers a glimpse into the poet's final chapter through his autobiography. He describes how Puman became increasingly absorbed in his fantastical dreams, drawing inspiration from these visions to craft his extraordinary and peculiar poetry. Ultimately, Puman succumbed to a dream so captivating that he lost all desire to return to reality. One sunny morning, he vanished from his bed, leaving behind a poem on the bedside table—a farewell of sorts.

Vanna, stepping forward to the very spot Puman was last seen, stooped to secure the crumpled scroll and pencil just as the wind threatened to carry them off.

With a puzzled frown, she unrolled the scroll and read the cryptic lines penned on it: "…I saw it, the sun has retreated, in the night, everything falls into tranquility… The ship sails from the sky, with stars like a curtain, granting the mortal world eternal slumber… In silence, in stillness, in sleep, the dead embrace the departed world…"

As the wind picked up, causing the paper to flutter, Vanna heard a voice whispering close to her ear—a voice that belonged to the vanished mad poet, though his form was nowhere to be seen. "Look, look, do you see?

The scene I saw… truly beautiful, the curtain rising from the end of the sea, reflecting over the entire world…”

Vanna turned her gaze in the direction from where the voice emanated, her eyes meeting nothing but the swirling dust that danced in the chaotic wind. Her eyebrows knitted together in a frown, her voice tinged with slight hoarseness as she asked, “Are you also trapped here?”

The voice, seemingly lost in its own world, continued to mutter to itself, its words initially muffled and disjointed. After a moment, however, the voice regained clarity.

“I’ve always been pursued by them, relentlessly, like hounds with a scent for blood… In every dream, I’ve stumbled across myriad places, each with its own crevice for me to seek refuge. Exhaustion eventually took hold, and the thought of being caught seemed less daunting… And so, I was engulfed by the hound known as truth, which led me to glimpse distant scenes before bringing me here…”

As Vanna absorbed the rambling discourse, she recognized the challenge in establishing a clear line of communication but felt compelled to inquire further, “Do you know how to leave this place?”

“No, no, no, one can’t simply leave, my friend…” The voice responded promptly, then trailed off into more unintelligible mutterings, “…Down in the basement, the robed ones proclaimed it a sanctuary, believing iron cages could imprison my spirit, preventing it from fleeing my corporeal form in dreams, and that braziers could repel the shadows lured by my essence, sparing me from total consumption in my slumber…”

The voice’s words became muddled with the wind and a cacophony of faint, indistinct sounds, only to emerge clearly once more: “…Do you understand, after many years… by then I had long been deceased, and years later, a young girl found herself ensnared in a similar cage. By that era, technology

had significantly advanced, and she emerged from the basement with her life intact…”

“Ah, the poor girl, I witnessed her ascension to power, and then her downfall, executed by those who once lauded her… I pondered whether to immortalize this in my poetry… no, no, better not. The robed ones forbade me from weaving the visions of my dreams into my verses, warning that it would strengthen my ties to realms beyond our own, which is undesirable… My opportunities to write grow scarce; I must reserve my remaining words for matters of greater importance…”

“Listen! The sound of someone knocking against the railing, the clinking of keys… ding ding, ding ding, ding ding. The guards are on their rounds, ensuring I remain confined…”

At that moment, the wind intensified, carrying with it the distinct sound of “ding ding ding,” reminiscent of keys.

And still, the mad voice continued its monologue: “But am I truly there? They might see me, seemingly at peace upon my bed, but I am absent, not within that husk; I reside here, in this realm of ashes… What brings you here?

“You ought to depart; this place is not for you, your journey lies beyond. Take my poetry, but my pencil… these items belong to me, not to be held by others… They will ensnare you, draw you into the depths…”

As Vanna stood there, the paper and pencil slipped from her grasp, transforming into sand with a whirl and vanishing into the air before she could react.

“Which direction should I take?” she inquired the voice, her question floating into the void, “I’ve lost track of where I came from, and I’m clueless about where I should head… How do I exit this city?”

“Any direction, any direction,” replied the voice, now sounding as if it were receding rapidly, its clarity diminishing into a faint echo, “This place is boundless… It’s ensnared in a perpetual dream of its own making. I’ve just seen it—beyond the city lies a desert, and beyond that desert, the city reclaims you. Escape is an illusion; the further you venture, the deeper you’re drawn in… But I must leave, I must awaken once more…”

And with those words, the voice faded entirely, lost to the wild dance of wind and sand.

Left alone, Vanna stood amidst the endless night, surrounded by lights that shone upon a city forgotten by time, her silhouette merging with the luminescence around her. Within the glow, she glimpsed ephemeral shadows of carriages traversing the fractured streets, vibrant storefronts amidst the ruins, and distant melodies that overtook the howling winds, their cadence soothing the sharp discomfort of myriad tiny cuts on her arms.

She briefly closed her eyes, almost ready to succumb to the seductive warmth and prosperity of this illusion.

But in an instant, her eyes flung open.

Something intangible had shattered within her, igniting a will that fought against the gentle, yet inexorable, pull towards oblivion. The phantoms dancing in the lights dimmed and vanished. The biting chill of the desert night cut across her face, the wind’s sting reviving the acute pain of countless minor injuries.

Yet, amidst this reality, she found a reason to smile—pain was a reminder, a confirmation of existence.

She understood that she did not belong to this surreal place. Despite not recalling her name or origin, one truth was clear: she was an outsider here.

Clinging to this realization was crucial—it was her defense against being assimilated by this land.

In this moment of awakening, Vanna grasped another vital insight: the necessity of finding her “anchor.”

It was imperative that she swiftly uncover her identity, recall her origins.

Gradually, memories and understandings began to trickle back, illuminating the essence of this vast desert. She recognized she had stumbled into a realm governed by “forgetfulness,” where resistance to “forgetting” was her only path forward.

Abandoning her aimless wanderings “outside” the city, she acknowledged the city’s “infinity.” Understanding that mere physical departure was insufficient for escape, she concluded there must exist another means of exit.

Bathed in the ambiguous glow of light, Vanna allowed the wind and the sand to pass over her, wearing away at her form. In this process, she found a semblance of peace, her mind gradually settling as she employed her thoughts and senses to navigate a path out of this maze.

She pieced together bits of information carried by the wind and embedded in the grains of sand—snippets of text, fragments of conversations, and remnants that seemed to echo different “times” and “events.” These snippets appeared to serve as various “anchors” within this vast desert of amnesia.

She reasoned that she, too, must have her own anchor—a testament to her existence somewhere, perhaps in the memories of certain individuals, within the… world itself.

With her eyelids drooping, a subtle stir began to take root in the depths of her heart after a duration that remained unmeasured.

In the midst of this infinite desert, she stumbled upon a trace that connected directly to her –

Vanna's eyes snapped open as a piece of torn paper fluttered by her. Swiftly catching it, she focused on the text it bore:

"…The border exploration fleet has once again embarked on the 'cross-border' operation. The Vanished and the Bright Star have breached the six-mile threshold… venturing towards the world's edge in search…"

Simultaneously, a familiar voice reached her, its tone fragmented as if snatched from a distant memory –

"…Any news of note?"

"…A dispatch from the Storm Church…"

"They'll be fine, try not to fret, Heidi…"

"Is it because of the renowned captain?"

"It's because of your dad…"

"Dad and Vanna, they are part of something truly grand…"

A surge of recognition flashed in Vanna's eyes, her heart finding its rhythm once more, pulsating with renewed life as if awakening from a long slumber. She remembered her name, and –

"The Vanished… Captain?"

Holding the paper, she whispered to herself, a mixture of realization and wonder in her voice.

Then, at the edge of her field of vision, a flicker of eerie green flame emerged, and almost instantly, a familiar yet imposing voice arose from behind her: "I am here."

Chapter 812: Sand and Fire

In an instant, the fragmented memories loudly pieced themselves back together, and Vanna’s confused and estranged thoughts snapped back into sharp focus as though the entire world had been set right with a single breath.

Once obscured by a haze of yellow sand as if under siege by unseen forces, the sky began to clear as the winds carried the sand away. Simultaneously, wisps of black smoke materialized from thin air, swirling and merging back into Vanna’s form. Memories of her name, her past, and the path that had led her to this moment flooded back. She remembered everything about the Vanished and the missions she had shared with her captain.

As she turned, her eyes met with the tall, dignified presence of Duncan standing beside her. He observed her silently, with a patience that suggested he had been there all along.

Taking a deep, steadying breath, Vanna shook off the lingering confusion and disorientation. After a moment of silent reflection, she murmured to herself, “It feels as though I’ve been ensnared in a lengthy dream—what a prolonged and winding journey it’s been.”

“Thankfully, you didn’t become utterly lost,” Duncan replied, a gentle smile playing at the corners of his mouth. “There was a time, amidst the ashes of the forgotten history, when your silhouette seemed almost imperceptible to me.”

A fleeting sensation of fear brushed against Vanna’s heart, but she quickly dismissed it. Looking around, she realized that the endless desert and the ruins it cradled hadn’t vanished with her return to clarity.

This place wasn’t merely a figment of her imagination, crafted solely for her benefit. It truly existed at this unique juncture, a peculiar “anomaly”—an eternal dream sustained by a ceaseless ember, an alternate layer of “reality.” She had awakened within the dream of an ancient deity yet hadn’t escaped this vast illusion.

Nevertheless, her awakening triggered a transformation. The once vivid and imminent vision of a bustling city receded into the shadows, and the phantom noises of streets and alleyways dissipated entirely. Now, the city lay in silence, a testament to ruin, lit only by floating orbs that cast a soft glow on the crumbled walls.

Reflecting on Duncan’s words, “the burned history,” Vanna began to grasp the true nature of this desert. She then recounted her visions: the coronation of the Frost Queen, a convocation during the era of archaeological discoveries among the old city-states, and the wanted posters of the Mist Fleet. These glimpses, she realized, were remnants of stories that the flames had spared.

Upon hearing Vanna’s observations, Duncan calmly offered, “…the afterglow lingers.”

Vanna’s expression shifted, adopting a grave demeanor as she remembered her initial encounter with this ash-covered isle, the subtle red glow buried within the warm ashes, and the distant columns of smoke rising into the sky.

“What about the others?” Vanna asked, momentarily pushing aside the nagging unease that tugged at her heart.

“They’ve pulled back to the ship for now,” Duncan replied casually. “The dynamics at this ‘node’ have shifted, possibly due to the critical conditions in Ta Ruijin, or maybe because ‘history’ as a concept holds unique significance here. The ash here is excessively perilous… I ventured here alone to find you.”

“I’ve caused you concern,” Vanna sighed, her voice tinged with regret.

“Let’s not dwell on that,” Duncan dismissed with a wave of his hand. “Instead, tell me what you’ve gone through. Do you still remember everything? What insights have you gathered about this ‘desert’ now?”

Vanna took a moment to steady her emotions and collect her thoughts, aware that the captain still had objectives to fulfill in this vast, sandy expanse. She began to share the details of what she still remembered about her ordeal in this endless desert – the whispers that reached her, the remnants of ruins she stumbled upon, and the distinct “ding, ding, ding” sound that accompanied the rise of the wind and sand.

She admitted that her recollections of the initial part of her “journey” were fuzzy at best. Upon her arrival in this boundless sea of sand, her mind was clouded for a considerable duration. Yet, one vivid impression remained –

“Forgetfulness and a sense of being lost dominate my earliest memories of the journey, almost as if I had intentionally etched those sensations into my subconscious. It’s as though I was conscious of the transformations occurring within me but was powerless to counter them. My only recourse was to engrain this feeling deeply within me, hoping it would later serve as a reminder of the ‘forgetfulness’ I experienced…

“My memories became clearer only after I had forgotten my name and my past. That’s when the ruins started appearing more frequently within the desert, and the voices began to emerge. This transition marked a gradual ‘assimilation,’ the most dangerous aspect of which was its subtlety. There

was no malevolence; it was akin to the erosion caused by a gentle breeze or the sun's rays – imperceptible until it was too late, and by the time I became aware, I found myself unable to leave the city."

As she shared this, Vanna took a cautious breath, still feeling a shiver of fear from the memory of her descent into confusion and the sense of being utterly lost. Then, something else came to her mind.

"Actually, before I recalled anything about the Vanished, I encountered someone else who seemed out of place here," she hurriedly added, "He told me his name was 'Puman.'"

"Puman?" Duncan's face showed a flicker of surprise, "The renowned 'mad poet'?"

"Yes, I was too bewildered at the time to recognize him, but now that my memories have returned, I'm certain he was the 'mad poet' chronicled in our history," Vanna confirmed with a nod, "He matched the descriptions from the literature perfectly, appearing tense yet courteous. He was inquiring about this place, seemingly in search of an exit."

Duncan reflected aloud, "Could he possibly be another 'shadow' cast by this desert?"

"I don't think so," Vanna replied with certainty, shaking her head. "He took physical form before me. He told me he had once again fallen into a dream and explained that, in the real world, he was confined to a basement, watched over by 'robed guardians' circling his 'prison.' It seems… he found his way here by accident."

"To accidentally stumble into the dream of an ancient deity at the world's end?" Duncan raised an eyebrow skeptically. "Even for someone as legendary as the 'mad poet,' that's somewhat hard to believe…"

He trailed off, lost in thought for a moment, before he connected the dots, “The details you’ve described sound remarkably like the containment facilities used by the church for natural-born psychics, as told by the Frost Queen, Ray Nora.”

“The Frost Queen… of course! That makes sense,” Vanna quickly realized, piecing together another fragment of the puzzle, “Puman even mentioned the Frost Queen, though he didn’t use her name explicitly. He must’ve been referring to her – someone who emerged years after his time, also trapped in a ‘cage’…”

Duncan listened intently to Vanna’s recounting, his mind racing with theories about the enigmatic “mad poet.” However, their speculation was cut short by a sudden, chilling gust of wind that swept through, reminding them of their present situation and priorities.

“We’ll delve into the ‘mad poet’s’ tale once we’re back. Morris and Lucretia are the experts in that field, not us; they’re the scholars,” Duncan stated with a sense of urgency. “Right now, our main goal is to locate Ta Ruijin and figure out how to get you out of this place safely.”

No sooner had Duncan finished speaking than a sound carried by the cold wind caught their attention – a distant, rhythmic tapping, like metal striking stone.

“Ding…ding ding…”

“That’s the sound!” Vanna recognized it instantly, turning to Duncan, “I’ve been hearing this sound all along. Whenever it echoes, something in the desert shifts; a new ruin emerges, or I hear those elusive voices…”

She paused, her thought interrupted.

The ding ding sound persisted, and then, Vanna noticed a change.

This time, the sound didn’t seem to emanate from everywhere; she could pinpoint its source.

After a moment of quick assessment and surprise, both she and Duncan pointed towards the heart of the city, exclaiming in unison, “…It’s coming from that direction!”

Though distant, the source of the sound was unmistakably clear now.

Without any further hesitation, they started towards the sound.

And that guiding noise did not fade; instead, the rhythmic ding ding ding continued to beckon them deeper into the city’s heart, growing ever more distinct as they progressed.

As they journeyed forward, Vanna’s mind circled back to the enigmatic advice given by the “mad poet” just before he vanished:

“The city stretches on endlessly, surrounded by the desert, and beyond the desert, the city resumes… Venturing outward, you’ll never escape this place.

To leave, you must not go outward but inward.

The ‘infinity’ of history unfolds in an unintuitive ‘one-way infinity’!

To find an exit or to seek the ancient deity overseeing history, the journey must be inward!”

Grasping the depth of his words, Vanna eagerly shared her epiphany with Duncan. Upon hearing her, Duncan simply nodded with a grave understanding and gestured around them.

“The city is fading away.”

Vanna, taken aback, surveyed her surroundings.

Indeed, the city was dissolving into the wind.

The decayed columns crumbled before their eyes, while streams of yellow sand cascaded from the lofty walls and towers. What began as a gradual disintegration swiftly accelerated into an expansive dispersal—the sand flowing like waterfalls from every elevated structure in the city, engulfing the dilapidated walls in dust. In mere moments, they, too, were swallowed by the desert.

Within a few short breaths, the entire city had vanished from view as though its presence had been nothing more than a mirage.

All that remained was the boundless expanse of sand.

And the sound, now almost tantalizingly close – Ding…ding ding…

Lifting her gaze, Vanna spotted a lone fire under the night sky. It reminded her of a similar beacon she had encountered in another dream amidst another desert sea long ago.

Beside this fragile flame, threatened by the cold wind yet resilient, sat a gigantic figure she recognized from another dream. In that memory, she had traveled alongside this ancient, towering presence. Now, he was there, his head bowed, tirelessly working with a chisel and stone in hand, etching into the sand beneath…

Ding…ding ding…

Chapter 813: The Pivotal Divergence

Ding… Ding Ding…

The sound echoes of a god meticulously etching into the sand with a chisel amidst the scorched remains of bygone eras.

To Vanna, the giant appears just as she remembered: aged, towering, with the wear and tear of countless eras etched into his visage like deep cuts from an axe. His hair and beard are unkempt, and his eyes appear deeply recessed.

Yet, in comparison to her memories, he looks even more withered and stooped over. His frayed robe seems to pulsate with a subtle, red glow as if the embers of a long-fading fire still cling to him. Tiny sparks occasionally escape from the edges of his garment as he moves, the flickering light casting short, ephemeral shadows onto the desert sands.

The giant raises his arm once more, the hammer meeting the chisel, and the chisel striking the loose sand, creating a crisp sound akin to metal striking stone. Despite the effort, sand proves to be a stubborn medium, leaving no mark, only the clear, echoing sound of the chisel across the vast desert.

Standing by a sand dune, Vanna observes this familiar scene from a distance. After a moment of hesitation, she takes a tentative step forward, following her captain’s lead.

Then, breaking the silence, the giant's deep, raspy voice reaches her: "Time… is an illusion, a construct placed by observers upon the changing world. History, then, is but a shadow cast by sentient beings within this illusory time. To these observers, meaning is founded on the existence of 'people'… without them, meaning fades away."

Vanna halts a few meters from the giant.

"There were once stones here, upon which history could be etched. But now, only sand remains, and even the flames have dwindled to but a faint glimmer," the giant muses to himself, glancing at a small bonfire struggling against the chill wind, "It's nearing its end."

"Civilization was birthed from flame and stone, and it shall conclude with them…" Vanna finds herself speaking out, echoing the words Ta Ruijin once shared with her in a profound dream at Wind Harbor.

At this, the giant lifts his head, his gaze meeting Vanna's.

"Not long ago, I had a fleeting dream, a memory from a distant, almost forgotten past, leaving behind only vague impressions… but within those shadows, I saw you," he says, looking into Vanna's eyes, a smile creasing the deep lines of his face, "Thank you for being there with me on that journey. Though the details escape me now… I still remember, it was a journey marked by solitude."

Vanna's eyes widen slightly in surprise: "You're referring to the dreamscape of Atlantis, how… how could you know about that?"

"In the moment when time is poised to complete its cycle, every event that has unfolded within the continuum of time is interlinked," Ta Ruijin acknowledges with a subtle nod, his voice resonating with a deep understanding. "In the early days of this sanctuary's inception, I was

intricately tied to its temporal currents… now, my knowledge spans broadly."

He then shifts his gaze towards Duncan, who stands close to Vanna.

"With patience, I've awaited your arrival, Flame Usurper," the giant says, his smile tinged with melancholy, "Yet, your presence here is a rare beacon of significance in this void of emptiness."

"To be frank, I hadn't envisioned this place to be as it is," Duncan admits, letting out a sigh, his honesty palpable. "I assumed… as the chronicler of civilization, you'd fare better than other 'deities.' After all, 'memory' falls under your dominion; you should possess greater resilience against 'decay.'"

Ta Ruijin shakes his head, a note of resignation in his voice. "Contrary to what one might expect, when the span of a catastrophe stretches far enough, the 'eradication of history' often happens before the extinction of the beings themselves," he explains. "It's not always that a race dies and then its history fades; more tragically, while a race still breathes, their history can already be forgotten… forgetting is a deep void."

He pauses, the weight of his reflection evident. "Forgetting is indeed a deep void, particularly when many aspects of this world can vanish abruptly. The 'corrections' within the sanctuary are insufficient to heal the gaps left by 'blasphemous prototypes,' leaving behind endless scars and cracks in the fabric of history. I've endeavored to conceal these points of historical distortion that could propagate corruption, tirelessly re-crafting the memories of the mortal realm, time and again… until stones turned to sand, and sand to dust, with nearly nothing left for restoration."

With a gesture of resignation, Ta Ruijin lets the stone and chisel fall from his grasp. As soon as they contact the yellow sand, they disintegrate, blending seamlessly with the desert floor.

Duncan advances towards the giant, whose seated form still towers above the tallest of men: “You’re aware of my purpose here.”

“Yes, Navigator Two has already briefed me,” Ta Ruijin responds, his voice steady and calm. “You’ve come to conclude this world, as I foresaw long ago… everything will be incinerated by your hand – this act is the initial step towards their salvation.”

Duncan locks eyes with the giant, curiosity evident in his question, “Are you speaking of the era before the sanctuary’s foundation, when you and the other ancient kings first encountered ‘me’? Is that why you’ve named me ‘Flame Usurper’… because you had glimpsed the future?”

“I may not possess the capability to compute the intricacies of the entire world like Navigator Two does, but I’ve been gifted with a vision that extends far into the timeline—though, admittedly, it’s not always as beneficial as one might hope,” Ta Ruijin says with a chuckle, a hint of wistfulness in his voice. “Back in the old world, those who placed their faith in me believed in this ability of mine, and so, it was within my reach.”

Duncan shares his inner turmoil, his voice reflecting a blend of contemplation and concern. “The notion of ‘burning everything’ has always been shadowed by my fear of reaching that ‘final burning,’” he confides. “This anxiety took root shortly after Navigator One introduced that ‘takeover strategy’ to me—a vision from a Doomsday Ender once showed me such a finale. In that particular version of history, my actions also led to the world’s end, yet the doom was inescapable.”

He pauses, revealing his deepest apprehension: “That’s been my primary worry, the only thing that’s truly haunted me—the final burning looms like an ominous shadow. I can’t help but feel… the conditions for its onset are eerily similar to the actions I’m about to undertake. If I proceed with ‘the first step,’ am I inadvertently steering us towards that disastrous final end?”

As they sit amidst the yellow sands, Ta Ruijin leans in, locking eyes with Duncan in a moment of profound connection before eventually breaking the gaze.

“There lies a crucial divergence,” he starts, his voice carrying the gravity of his years. “Whether we consider Navigator One’s scheme or your current course of action, ‘burning the world’ appears as an inevitable ‘first step.’ However, the real distinction… hinges on who you are at the moment you initiate this plan.”

At the mention of the “Eternal Flame,” a lightbulb goes off in Duncan’s head!

A key insight, previously elusive and now crystal clear, dawns on him.

Moved by an instinctual urge, he inches closer, his gaze piercing into the giant’s eyes: “Are you suggesting…”

“The influence wielded by Captain Duncan is finite,” Ta Ruijin articulates with serene clarity, “You’ve dwelled within this avatar for an extended period, yet… it remains, fundamentally, just an avatar.”

Duncan’s realization is palpable as he stares down at his hands, coming to terms with the root of his underlying disquiet, comprehending the source of his instinctual apprehensions…

It’s the “self” confined within this form, sensing the avatar’s limitations and issuing a subconscious caution.

He is not merely Duncan; he is Zhou Ming.

Duncan represents merely one of his incarnations, akin to the antique shopkeeper in Pland or the graveyard caretaker in Frost—the captain of the Vanished, merely one among three facades.

Duncan’s initial spiritual odyssey commenced with the activation of that brass compass—whereas Zhou Ming’s inaugural spiritual venture began the moment he stepped through the fog from his bachelor apartment.

With a deep breath, he allows this newfound understanding to anchor within him.

In reality, Zhou Ming had already begun to intuit certain truths about his identity, recognizing that his so-called “true self” aboard the Vanished was fundamentally no different from the “corpse avatars” he utilized in Pland and Frost. He understood that “Duncan” was his inaugural persona in this world, yet he hadn’t fully explored the deeper implications of this realization—

The question of whether he was fundamentally Duncan or Zhou Ming had been crucial from the very beginning.

Reflecting on this… Zhou Ming’s brow furrows as he remembers the initial encounter with Goathead upon his arrival on the Vanished. He recalls the entity’s acute awareness of his presence and its persistent inquiry – “Name?”

“Just as you’re starting to grasp the significance of this question,” Ta Ruijin’s voice unexpectedly interrupts Duncan’s reverie, bringing a sharp focus back to the present, “Might I suggest you temper your thoughts somewhat? The brilliance of your starlight is nearly blinding.”

Duncan comes to a sudden realization, noticing for the first time the subtle starlight radiating from him. This soft luminescence has begun to envelop the surrounding yellow sands, as if dipping the desert itself into a vast, star-filled night sky.

Ta Ruijin, meanwhile, gathers his worn robe around him as if to shield himself from the starlight’s glow, his voice carrying a note of resignation.

Standing close by, Vanna seems unaffected, yet there’s a puzzled look on her face.

She appears much like a student who, while standing next to her mentor, finds herself lost in the complexity of the conversation.

In response, Duncan offers an awkward cough: “Uh… my apologies.”

Following his words, the starlight that had subtly illuminated the surroundings begins to withdraw.

Chapter 814: Bonfire

As Duncan slowly came back to his senses, the brilliant glow of starlight that had previously covered the sand began to recede, disappearing as if it had never been there at all. This light seemed to be absorbed back into Duncan himself.

Witnessing this, Ta Ruijin also breathed a sigh of relief as if a weight had been lifted from his shoulders. Then, the being known as the “Eternal Flame” shifted his attention to Vanna, who was standing a short distance away.

As the starlight faded, Vanna seemed unaffected by its presence or departure. It was as though she was entirely unaware of the starlight’s disappearance, lost in her thoughts much like Duncan had been just moments before. It was only after some time had passed that she looked up and began to take in the changes in her environment and herself – a faint purple glow remained at the tips of her silver-white hair, suggesting that the starlight had always been a part of her, only now becoming visible under a certain mystical illumination.

Breaking the silence, Ta Ruijin spoke up, directing his words towards Vanna. “You’ve been subtly influenced by the power of the Flame Usurper, becoming an embodiment of his essence,” he said, acknowledging her with a slight nod. “This confirms my suspicions – the true nature of the Flame Usurper’s essence isn’t in the flames themselves, but hidden beneath them.”

Vanna started to understand the depth of the conversation happening between the captain and this ancient deity. Her expression changed several

times as she processed the information.

Turning his attention back to Duncan, Ta Ruijin continued, “In reality, Flame Usurper, you’ve never fully entered this world. You’ve been observing the complexities of the Boundless Sea from afar, through a veil, only occasionally seeing its true essence with your own eyes. And I believe I understand the significance of this ‘flaming end’ you’ve mentioned. It’s a result of your limited perspective.”

“The act of ‘usurping’ Navigator One is tied to the necessity of preserving this sanctuary. To protect it, you must remain fully aware of its condition… you must continue to be ‘Duncan.’”

Ta Ruijin paused, giving Duncan time to digest his words before speaking again, this time more softly, “The Flame Usurper’s gaze, if fully unleashed, could lead to the destruction of this world. Its presence depends on your perception.

“On the other hand, when you need to take ‘the first step,’ you must embrace the identity of the Flame Usurper. It’s ‘Captain Duncan’s’ perspective that will maintain the sanctuary amid the flames, leading to ‘the end of the flame.’ This outcome, beyond your personal intent, may be the one thing in this world you cannot avoid.”

Duncan stayed quiet, pondering Ta Ruijin’s profound statements, contemplating his role in Navigator One and his own plans…

In this narrative, the perceptions of “Duncan” and “Zhou Ming” reveal different aspects of the world.

After a lengthy silence, Duncan, still embodying his role as “Duncan,” finally spoke, “I understand,” he said quietly, his gaze meeting Ta Ruijin’s. “Thank you for the reminder. It’s indeed crucial.”

“Good,” Ta Ruijin responded with a smile. Then, showing the strain in his ancient, bent figure, he slowly pushed himself up from the sand, standing with a mix of determination and effort.

As he stood, sand flowed off his body like the last grains in an hourglass, a poignant reminder of time’s relentless march. The night wrapped its dark cloak around the desert, and he, in the midst of this timeless landscape, fixed his eyes on the far-off horizon.

After a moment of contemplation, he exhaled a soft, almost mournful breath, “There’s scarcely anything left…”

Upon hearing his somber reflection, Vanna couldn’t help but ask, “What was this place before?”

“Before? It hardly was a bustling hub even in its prime. From the beginning, the ‘history’ we speak of in the sanctuary was more like a shadow in the flow of time—a mere outline of mine, fleshed out and maintained by the ritual efforts of those who tended the flames. They crafted a semblance of a world moving forward, enduring through the ages. But this place, it was never brimming with life as we know it.”

“Yet, it wasn’t always this barren desert. Once, in what now stretches as an endless dry expanse, there were rivers and oases, rare as they might have been. Despite the illusory nature of time here, it bore witness to events worthy of note.”

“Back then, cities rose near these water sources, home to intelligent beings other than humans. These cities were as if reflections in a mirror, cast by the real world into this dream I had spun. In their shared memory, the world was flourishing, forever prosperous.”

Bending down, the ancient figure scooped up a handful of sand, watching it trickle through his fingers, taken by the cool night air.

“Then, decay set in. The real world began losing its vibrancy, and as it did, the sanctuary’s record of history grew fragmented and incomplete. With every self-correction this place underwent, more decay, like gangrene, crept into its narrative. The once fertile land was slowly consumed by the encroaching sands, its past whispers echoing in the ruins left behind, leading to the desolation you see now.”

Vanna thought back to the city ruins she had explored, the voices she had heard echoing through the vast desert, and the artifacts she had seen, all of which had seemed so real at the time.

Then, a memory struck her—the “theories” and “heretical speculations” she had once stumbled upon in the cathedral archives of Pland. These texts spoke of a world’s duality.

Some theorists had suggested that our world was split, that somewhere, there existed a parallel realm where the sea and land were inverted—a vast, dry wasteland punctuated by the rare oasis or river, home to civilizations that mirrored our own in some eerie, reflective dance.

With widened eyes, Vanna looked out into the distance, her mind painting vivid images of ancient city-states that lay in ruins across the desert sands…

This was the realm those scholars had speculated about, a mirrored version of our world.

And it was real—tucked away at the edge of the world, cradled in the fading memories of an ancient deity.

Vanna suddenly looked up as though she was about to say something important to Ta Ruijin. However, before she could utter a word, a powerful gust of wind whipped through the air, stirring the sand into a frenzy.

The sandstorm rose like a thick curtain separating the heavens from the earth, engulfing both her and the captain. Then, as quickly as it had arrived,

it disappeared, leaving behind a calm. The formidable figure of Ta Ruijin, who had just been standing in the desert, was now nowhere to be seen.

In the midst of daylight that broke through the clouds and mist, shedding light on the ash-strewn landscape, a gentle breeze picked up, causing the pale ash to dance in the air, reminiscent of a delicate fabric moving in the wind.

Coming back to reality, Vanna surveyed her surroundings, her eyes scanning the horizon. All she could see was a vast expanse of ash, punctuated here and there by columns of smoke that twisted upwards towards the sky.

Not too far from her position, the remains of a bonfire struggled to stay alight, its flames flickering weakly on the verge of being snuffed out.

Next to this dying fire sat Ta Ruijin. The once powerful giant now appeared frail and withered, his form barely more than a skeleton. It was as though he himself had become part of the fire, his body the kindling, with only a weak, trembling flame emanating from what remained of him, fluttering in the wind.

He sat there, head hung low, with something that had once been beside him now reduced to indistinct ashes. His hand clutched a piece of black stone, suggesting he had been intensely focused on some task until movement eluded him.

Vanna moved closer to the feeble fire, her gaze lingering on the giant’s face in silent contemplation.

Lost in her thoughts, she thought she heard that distinct sound again –

Ding… Ding Ding…

At that moment, Duncan came up to her, placing his hand gently on her shoulder.

“It’s time to go,” he murmured softly, “while the fire still burns.”

Vanna gave a small nod in agreement.

Duncan then reached out, his finger extended towards the embers next to Ta Ruijin.

Without a word, the flames subtly shifted to a soft green glow, their light now resembling the sparkle of distant stars, slowly flickering as if breathing.

In the midst of the fire’s last dance, Duncan whispered to himself, “See you in our new world.”

…

Far away, under the cover of an eternal night, a vast fleet made its way northward.

The night wind swept across the calm sea, bringing with it the piercing cold of the northern waters, a cold that seemed to seep into one’s very soul. The dim, ethereal light of the fissuring World’s Creation illuminated the scene, revealing icebergs floating on the dark, reflective surface of the sea. Their ghostly forms cast shifting shadows, moving both slowly and swiftly, accompanying the ships on their journey.

Even the mighty bonfire, often seen as a beacon of warmth and safety, could not dispel the penetrating chill that seemed to engulf the sea. Frem, standing by the central bonfire on the deck of the Cathedral Ark, felt a sudden shift in the atmosphere. What was typically a source of heat and comfort now felt as though it radiated no warmth at all. Instead, a profound coldness, as if emanating from a bottomless abyss, seeped through, biting into his very bones.

The sound of footsteps approaching interrupted Frem, the Flame Bearer Pope, from his contemplation. He turned toward the noise and saw a

priestess dressed in a black gown adorned with flame-like patterns, her face obscured by a veil, approaching him. She walked with a deliberate grace towards the bonfire, then bowed respectfully in his presence.

“Your Holiness, we have navigated through Frost’s waters and have just received communication from the vessels of the Storm Church. They have confirmed they will meet with us in thirty minutes to hand over the ‘goods,’” she informed him.

“Mm,” Frem responded, his mind still partly on the unsettling cold, “…And the archives? Are they ready to receive?”

“The storage has been arranged,” the tall orcish priestess assured him. “We have made space in our storage compartments to accommodate the incoming documents.”

Frem gave a nod, his expression one of tacit approval.

“There’s more,” the priestess added, “We’ve also received a message from Frost. Governor Tyrian sends his regards, along with a message:

“‘May the blessings of the world be upon you. Greetings to those who record and inherit. Move forward with assurance, for every effort to preserve is of value. In addition: ‘they’ have traversed the domain of flame and are now making their way to the final node.’”

Her report finished, the priestess stood silently by, awaiting any further instructions or questions from Frem, her posture embodying the solemn duty and the weight of the message she had just delivered.

Chapter 815: And Then, Death

As the fleet journeyed farther north, the chill in the air intensified, suggesting that the coldness had become an inherent characteristic of the sea that lay before them. Despite the warmth of the flames or the layers of winter clothing they wore, these measures only managed to fend off the biting cold temporarily, failing to provide true warmth.

During one particularly frigid and endless night, the Storm Church delivered its last set of documents to the Church of the Flame Bearers' Ark. This exchange occurred under the cover of darkness, with the vessel from the Storm Church docking alongside the Flame Bearers' Ark for several hours before it retreated back into the obscurity of the night.

Frem, positioned atop the Ark's high tower, watched as the departing ship's outline grew increasingly indistinct against the distant sea. The sound of steam whistles from the ship lingered in the night, blending with the wind before fading away completely.

"This may well be our final glimpse of others from the civilized world," remarked the towering pope of the forest folk, turning to address the priestess by his side. "Following this exchange, our temple will remain in the north. The Ark is not just our vessel; it is our archive, and the archive, in essence, is the Ark itself."

"We are fully prepared for what lies ahead," the priestess responded with a calm demeanor. "We will make our stand amidst the eternal ice, witnessing the last embers of light pierce through the darkness until this prolonged

night comes to an end… It is a profound honor to be here with you, Your Holiness.”

Frem paused momentarily before replying softly, “The honor is mine as well.”

At the edge of his vision, far ahead of the Ark fleet, a faint white mass began to emerge from the sea.

This was the frozen expanse in the farthest reaches of the Cold Sea, the world’s most frigid region, where everything is ensnared by ice, achieving a form of eternity within its grasp. This is the final destination for the Flame Bearers.

The city-state they left behind had lost its fragment of the sun several days prior when a tugboat transported the enormous glowing object to a place where it was needed more. Now, the city relied solely on artificial lighting. The bright glow of street lamps and the lights from countless homes merged together, creating a luminous flow that traced the city’s contours, maintaining the semblance of order and tranquility that civilization clings to.

It seems that people have gradually acclimated to this prolonged darkness.

The newly implemented curfew system is functioning without a hitch, and after an initial period of unrest and confusion, factories and markets have resumed their orderly activities. Though residents have limited the frequency of their outings, they continue to uphold their daily routines within the constraints allowed. Despite a few acts of sabotage orchestrated by dissenters in the shadows against the city, these were swiftly quelled by the combined efforts of the guardians and the sheriff’s forces.

The “Sunlight Fleet,” tasked with transporting a fragment of the sun, navigates the vast ocean between city-states. Accompanying this fleet, a

massive convoy of cargo ships traverses the night, successfully restoring sixty to seventy percent of the inter-city bulk logistics transportation. The periodic arrival of the “sunlight” brought by the fleet has significantly alleviated the pressures that have mounted on each city during this prolonged night. Despite the increasing occurrences of distortions and mutations, the guardians, for the first time in a long while, find a moment to catch their breath—

They are grappling with unprecedented challenges, yet it’s a welcome change from the relentless despair that once shrouded them in darkness.

At times, Tyrian finds himself contemplating the sustainability of this new status quo—a delicate balance seems to have been struck. Civilization has demonstrated remarkable resilience and adaptability throughout this enduring night. The populace has grown accustomed to the prolonged darkness, bolstered by the solidarity among city-states, the implementation of the curfew system, the establishment of a new night watch order, and the itinerant rays of sunlight. These measures appear sufficient to sustain this semblance of normalcy, potentially for an extended period, if not indefinitely.

However, such thoughts are fleeting, as Tyrian soon comes to a stark realization: this sense of tranquility is but an illusion, a temporary reprieve from the reality that the world is inexorably spiraling towards its demise, at a pace far exceeding anyone’s expectations.

This awareness stems from his understanding of the “decay” afflicting the gods, the gradual yet irreversible deterioration at the world’s foundation—knowledge inherited from his father.

But what about others? Tyrian wonders about the perception of city-state governors, church administrators, guardians, sheriffs, and the ordinary

citizens. Do they, too, harbor this false sense of peace, unknowingly ensnared by this deceptive calm?

“…Maybe it’s not a bad thing,” Tyrian mutters to himself.

Caught off guard, Aiden inquires, “Huh? What’s not a bad thing?”

“Nothing, just thinking out loud,” Tyrian replies, shifting his focus from the distant city lights to gaze upon Aiden’s gleaming bald head. “What were we discussing?”

“We were talking about the need to adjust production in several factories in the lower city district,” Aiden begins, before quickly adding, “The Coordinating Committee has raised concerns about a slight shortfall in fuel production capacity. While it’s not a pressing issue at the moment, they predict it will become more severe over time…”

“I’m aware; I reviewed the report earlier today. Inform the Coordinating Committee that City Hall will provide a response by tomorrow morning,” Tyrian dismisses the topic with a wave of his hand. “Is there anything else?”

A moment of hesitation creeps into Aiden’s voice, tinged with uncertainty, “Well, there’s something… unusual reported by the Great Furnace.”

“Something unusual?” Tyrian’s expression shifted to one of mild irritation, his brow furrowing in frustration. “Please, let’s not dance around the details. Who reports in such a vague manner?”

Aiden hastily cleared his throat, realigning his posture and demeanor before responding, “There’s been a report from a department stating they’ve been without tasks for some time now. The head of that department has expressed… a sense of oddity about the situation.”

Tyrian’s concern visibly deepened, a sense of disquiet washing over him as if crucial pieces of information were eluding his grasp. “A department?

What exactly do you mean by ‘a department’? Which department are we talking about here?”

“The report was somewhat disorderly, and it landed on my desk in a state of confusion. It’s unclear who sent it. Many parts of the document are illegible…” Aiden’s explanation grew increasingly befuddled, his expression turning into one of utter bewilderment. His speech slowed, his words coming out as if he were a machine grinding to a halt, painstakingly forcing out each word: “…I just recall… they… were in charge of… incineration…”

He paused, his expression vacant, as he stared blankly at Tyrian.

After a brief moment of silence, Aiden appeared to snap back to reality, a tremor running through him before he proceeded as if the previous exchange hadn’t occurred. “…The production capacity of the metal ore mine has returned to pre-night levels. The surplus ore is currently being prepared for shipment. Upon the Sunlight Fleet’s next visit, it will be transported as scheduled…”

However, Tyrian seemed to have tuned out Aiden’s update regarding the metal ore mine. From the moment Aiden resumed speaking, Tyrian’s gaze had fixed on him with an intensity that bordered on alarming, causing Aiden to falter under the heavy, unspoken question hanging in the air: “Uh… did I say something wrong?”

“Aiden,” Tyrian’s voice was laden with a gravity that underscored the years of loyalty and service between them, “do you recall what you were just reporting to me?”

Aiden, taken aback, reviewed their conversation with a puzzled look. “The… the production capacity of the metal ore mine, adjustments in the factory production in the lower city districts, the Coordinating Committee’s

concerns about fuel shortages? Before that, we discussed the Flame Bearers fleet heading north…"

He trailed off, noticing the increasingly perturbed look on Tyrian's face.

"The Great Furnace," Tyrian stated, his voice and demeanor conveying deep seriousness, "do you remember telling me about a report from a department in the Great Furnace?"

Aiden's expression blanked: "…What report?"

Tyrian remained silent, his gaze drifting toward the outskirts of the upper city district, in the direction of a particular cemetery.

As a gust of wind wound its way through the night, stirring the streets and venturing into the heart of the cemetery, it carried with it a mist of gray-white dust. Within the swirl of the wind, the figure of Agatha began to coalesce from the dust.

Today, Agatha had forsaken her bishop's solemn black attire in favor of the light armor and combat jacket she wore during her tenure as a gatekeeper. The cracks adorning her cheeks and arms, reminiscent of the fissures on a fragile doll, emanated a soft, green glow. She made her way hastily from the Silent Cathedral in the upper city district to the cemetery, yet upon her arrival, she was met with an unexpected sight.

Duncan, the towering figure wrapped in bandages who served as the cemetery's caretaker, was positioned beside a mortuary table located on a narrow path within the cemetery. He was assisting a figure that appeared to have recently been a corpse, evidenced by its neck bent at an odd angle and its head lolling to one side. The figure clumsily descended from the table, its movements rigid and accompanied by the disconcerting sound of cracking joints.

The gravekeeper Duncan, while helping the reanimated corpse down, maintained a serene demeanor: "…Yes, experiencing some headache is to be expected. Perhaps you'll feel better once you've returned… Your neck needs to be stabilized, either a wooden brace or fire tongs should suffice. Try to remain positive. Think of this as if you've simply wandered off after having a bit too much to drink. Your family won't hold this against you—they'll be glad to have you back. After all, there are many others like you."

While he was speaking, another mortuary table nearby creaked as its coffin lid was pushed open. An elderly man with white hair sat up, looking around in confusion: "Why am I lying here? My chest feels tight…"

"I'll assist you in a moment," Duncan promptly responded, moving towards him. "Please, don't try to get down by yourself. A broken limb might be somewhat more… problematic to deal with… Yes, breathe. Feeling tightness in your chest is normal after being in there for so long… that's it, deep breaths, inhale the air—"

Duncan halted mid-sentence, turning his head to acknowledge the gatekeeper, Agatha, who stood on the path, her expression one of utter astonishment.

"Oh, you've arrived," he greeted her with an air of nonchalance.

"…Mr. Duncan," Agatha, still trying to process the scene before her, managed to say, "What exactly are you doing?"

"It seems your understanding of the situation hasn't fully adjusted yet," Duncan remarked indifferently before returning his attention to his peculiar task. "As you can see, I'm helping my temporary 'guests' find their way back."

Chapter 816: Merging into the Long Night

In the graveyard, the deceased were emerging from their coffins with an unsettling persistence, their bodies meandering through the tombstones. They roamed without direction, posing questions with evident confusion, or positioned themselves on the cold, hard surfaces of the morgue slabs, lost in a bewildered state. They engaged in futile reflections and deliberations amidst the lingering discord that remained after the collapse of the familiar world they once knew, attempting to come to terms with the discomfort and ominous shadows that now plagued their existence.

The caretaker, whose duty was to oversee the cemetery and thwart any disturbances that might awaken the dead, found himself in an unusual role. He was now shepherding these resurrected beings, guiding them from their temporary graves back to their earthly homes.

The dimly lit streetlights cast a ghostly illumination over the scene, intensifying the surreal atmosphere. Agatha, despite being disconnected from the sensations of the living, felt an icy chill creeping from the depths of her being. She stood frozen by the pathway, her eyes fixed on Duncan as he escorted the reanimated deceased, one by one, out of the cemetery. It was as though she was caught in an eerie, dreamlike state.

“You’re the last one,” Duncan eventually announced to the final departed soul, a young man whose life had been claimed by violence, evidenced by the stark wound across his chest. With a blend of gentleness and assurance,

Duncan assisted the newly risen from his resting place, advising, “You recall the route to your house, don’t you? Proceed home. It’s expected to feel a sense of breathlessness; this sensation will become familiar in time… Head home, reunite with your family. Avoid overthinking; live your life to the fullest – depart from this place, move forward, and never glance back. For the foreseeable future, there’s no necessity for you to return here.”

As the last of the departed staggered off, the faint glow of the streetlight followed his departure until he merged with the obscurity of the night.

Duncan then made his way to the gatekeeper, Ms. Agatha. Beneath layers of bandages, his eyes conveyed a warmth and serenity: “My apologies for the delay, Miss Agatha.”

A wave of bewilderment washed over Agatha, bringing with it a premonition of forgetting something crucial. However, she quickly regained her composure, pressing a hand to her forehead while whispering, “The line separating life and death has blurred… Captain, what’s unfolding? There’s a strangeness permeating… the cemetery… it’s far from normal…”

She tottered slightly, her consciousness flickering as though she was on the verge of collapse.

“Take a moment, Agatha,” Duncan reassured her, extending his arm for support and guiding her gently towards a morgue slab to rest beside a coffin.

“Try to remain composed, whether you’re breathing or not,” he advised, echoing the comfort he had offered to the restless spirits earlier, “It’s normal to feel weak and a bit anxious; these feelings will diminish shortly. Tyrian has already adjusted, and so will you.”

Comforted by his presence and words, Agatha felt the turmoil within her mind begin to ebb, her thoughts stabilizing. After a brief silence, she softly

inquired, “How much longer?”

“We’re on our way to the final point now, the realm ruled by the god of death. Based on what we’ve encountered before, it’s likely to be a journey of about two or three days. After we reach there, I’ll be able to assess Bartok’s condition accurately,” Duncan said, locking eyes with Agatha, whose gaze was obscured by a black veil. “However, if you’re inquiring about what lies beyond that, the ultimate end… it’s going to require more time.”

“…And what will become of our world?”

Duncan remained silent, offering only a steady, contemplative look in response.

At that moment, he was reminded of a future the Black Sun had shown him – a future where the sea forgets the motion of waves, where life loses its grasp on the art of dying, where flames no longer know how to ignite, where the wind ceases its journey, where clouds descend from their lofty heights to meet the sea…

Gods would fade into nothingness, and the world, in its descent into obscurity, would forget – this was the “decaying future.”

It stood as a bleak counterpart to the “future of flames.”

Agatha’s question went unanswered, but she sensed an understanding of the inevitable outcome within Duncan’s gaze. As the familiar conflict and contradictions in her mind began to resurface, she faintly realized… such cataclysms might not be the first to this world.

“…I’ve been through the most rigorous training and trials. I honed my abilities within the temple walls, fortified my resolve. I took an oath before the sacred statue of the Lord to use my strength and faith to safeguard those under our care…”

Her words trailed off, a chilling sensation penetrating her consciousness as if her thoughts were being encased in ice. Her voice, carrying through the cold night air, seemed to originate from one grave and resonate into another.

“But how can I safeguard them under these circumstances? Captain Duncan, when the very foundations of our world are crumbling…”

“You are safeguarding them, and everyone in this city is contributing to its protection in their own unique ways – preserving the way of life, the memories, everything,” Duncan interrupted her with a deep, resonant voice. “I understand that despite our efforts, everything is gradually inching towards oblivion. The ‘memory’ of the world is slipping away, like sand escaping a clenched fist. Holding on tighter might slow the process, but no one is to blame.”

He then turned his gaze towards the cemetery path and the morgue slabs alongside it, which had now fallen silent.

Some slabs still displayed the scars of bullets and blades, adorned with flowers laid by the living in memory of the dead, and even… what appeared to be fresh tear marks.

This place had witnessed conflicts over the border between life and death, mourners paying tribute to those who had departed, and now it rested in silence. It was likely that, for a considerable time to come, it would no longer welcome any “visitors.”

Over time, the significance of cemeteries would fade from collective memory, leading to their inevitable neglect. The transition from life to death would become a mere change of state, eliciting no concern or attention. Bartok’s role within the priesthood would grow dim, and the notion of a church dedicated to death would evolve into a concept that, while natural, remains beyond the comprehension of many, with no one seeking to understand it. In this dwindling world, a new adaptation would arise –

“ignorance” would emerge as a kind of mercy bestowed upon beings. This ignorance serves to shield the fragile minds of mortals from the harsh reality of rot and decay that festers unseen.

Agatha experienced the chill of the air filling her lungs and then slowly releasing. It dawned on her that she hadn’t taken a breath in quite some time. After her physical demise, she had increasingly embraced her identity among the deceased, gradually losing the instinct to “breathe.”

But in that moment, she found herself breathing effortlessly once again.

The darkness of the night tenderly wrapped around the world, clearing the fog from her mind, soothing all her disquiet.

Beside her, Captain Duncan’s voice resonated, his words offering calm and assurance.

“Agatha, did you know? Humans are actually capable of seeing their own noses – it obstructs a significant portion of their field of vision. When both eyes focus, it casts a theoretically unavoidable shadow.”

“Yet, your brain has adapted to this ‘problem.’ It learns to overlook the shadow, cleverly filling in the gaps in your perception with its remarkable imagination. Only from certain angles and in specific conditions does the existence of this ‘blind spot’ become apparent.”

“Furthermore, owing to the way our nervous system is structured, we actually perceive the world upside down. The brain expends considerable effort to invert the images relayed by our nerves to present them the right way up – leading to situations where neurological anomalies cause some individuals to perceive everything upside down, struggling to navigate their environment.”

“Such are the imperfections of human beings that their brains must engage in a process of ignoring, forgetting, and even deceiving themselves to

navigate this world logically."

"Similarly, this world possesses a 'correction' mechanism akin to that of the human brain – concealing those dreadful inconsistencies and contradictions under its guise. Though these issues continue to accumulate, and the world gradually declines… this arrangement represents the best effort 'They' could muster."

"Agatha, this world is so flawed that its architects had to rely on a strategy of neglect, oblivion, and self-deception to ensure you could live sensibly within it. And now, we are approaching the limits of this process."

"It's like sand escaping between our fingers."

"But 'They' did the best they could."

Duncan withdrew his gaze from the horizon, his attention returning to the gatekeeper seated on the morgue slab.

"…I will return to the cathedral," Agatha declared softly.

A faint greenish glow emanated from within her shattered form, concentrated where her eyes once shone with life.

"People will flock to the cathedral in search of solace, and there will be other clergy like myself, momentarily lost in confusion and distress. They depend on me – and beyond that, when this 'phase' momentarily ceases, I shall persist in performing my sacred obligations… I belong among the faithful, ensuring the continuity of their lives, even if it's just for one additional day. And then…"

With a gentle sigh, she gracefully descended from the morgue slab, her movements reflecting agility.

Standing in the darkness, she resembled a resolute monument, her past days of devotion within the cathedral, garbed in long ceremonial robes, in no

way lessening her presence as a guardian.

“Then, the situation may deteriorate further,” Duncan’s voice resonated nearby, “Life has lost its grasp on the concept of death, and perhaps flames will next forget their essence to ignite. Wind and clouds, light and darkness, numerous elements will slowly succumb to this relentless decay – and the ‘correction’ mechanisms of the world will be stretched to their limits. There will be those who awaken in the darkness, confronting the true terror of our existence. By that time…”

Agatha lifted her gaze, meeting Captain Duncan’s eyes with determination. A gentle wind began to stir around her, and her form started to disintegrate into ashes, carried away by the breeze.

A smile graced her face.

“I will continue to uphold my duties and wait with patience – we all have our respective roles to fulfill, don’t we?”

Duncan offered a soft nod in agreement.

As Agatha’s essence transformed into a whirlwind of ash, it blended into the nocturnal air, leaving the silent graveyard behind.

Chapter 817: The Journey Nears Its End

The atmosphere aboard the Vanished was heavy with a foreboding sense of conclusion as the ship and the Bright Star traversed through a serene yet monotonous landscape dominated by shades of gray and white. The impending end seemed to hang in the air, palpable to all aboard, even though Duncan refrained from vocalizing the sentiment.

In the dining area of the Vanished, the crew had gathered, with Lucretia relinquishing control of her ship to the unlikely pair of a doll named Luni and a rabbit named Rabbi, joining the rest at the long table.

Beside Duncan sat the enigmatic figure known as the “Sea Witch,” accompanied by Nilu, a diminutive doll recently welcomed into the crew of the Bright Star. It was Nilu’s first appearance among them, perched delicately on her mistress’s shoulder, her tiny hands gripping Lucretia’s hair as she observed her surroundings with wide-eyed curiosity.

Noticing Nilu’s elegant appearance, Shirley couldn’t resist the temptation to play a prank. “Hey-ha—”

Startled, Nilu let out a surprised cry, clutching onto Lucretia’s hair tightly for comfort.

Observing Nilu’s reaction, Lucretia gently reassured the doll, listening as Nilu softly confessed, “She frightened me.”

Shirley, feigning innocence, quickly diverted her attention back to the ongoing briefing led by the captain.

Seemingly unperturbed by the minor disturbance, Duncan shifted the conversation towards the challenges posed by the Boundless Sea.

“In the cities, the undead mingle with the living, rendering graveyards and crematoriums obsolete. The dead wander aimlessly, while the living exist in a state of listless stagnation, with the natural cycles of life and death disrupted. To outsiders, these distortions are unfathomable, yet they’ve become the unsettling norm, either rationalized or ignored.”

“The plight of the Storm Church mirrors that of the Death Church. Their fundamental beliefs have twisted into unrecognizable, heretical forms, yet daily life continues as if nothing is awry. However, this adaptation to a ‘corrected’ reality is unsustainable.”

A somber silence fell over the group, with Shirley’s earlier levity replaced by a sober mood in the wake of Duncan’s chilling portrayal.

Turning to Vanna, Duncan inquired gently, “How are you coping?”

Visibly distressed, Vanna furrowed her brow and replied, “Reconstructing one’s cognition isn’t a simple task.” Contemplating Duncan’s words, she managed a wistful smile and shook her head. “I had almost forgotten about ‘the waves.’ This unexpected encounter has stirred those memories, leaving me feeling as though the fabric of reality itself is unraveling.”

Vanna paused, her expression conveying intense concentration as she grappled with articulating her complex emotions. “It’s like there are two conflicting ‘cognitive systems’ battling in my mind. One part of me is keenly aware of certain truths, while another refuses to acknowledge them, dismissing them as incomprehensible or non-existent. It’s as if both perceptions have firmly rooted themselves in my consciousness, like…”

Her voice trailed off as she sought an analogy to encapsulate her inner conflict.

“Perhaps something akin to ‘hydrophobia’?” Duncan interjected calmly.

“Yes, that feeling of believing ‘water is poisonous’…” Vanna mused, nodding slowly. “Indeed. The battles waged within the mind are always more challenging than those in the physical realm.”

With a pensive expression, Duncan shared his strategy for addressing Vanna’s cognitive dissonance. “I had contemplated the necessity of reinforcing and stabilizing your cognition,” he began, his gaze scanning the assembled group. There was a hint of a green fire dancing in his eyes as if reaching out to touch the essence of their beings, binding their consciousness more closely to his vision. “However, considering what lies ahead, it is crucial for me to bestow upon you these flames. Only with them could you serve as my most reliable ‘anchor.’”

Lucretia reacted subtly to Duncan’s proclamation. Though she appeared poised to offer her own insights, she ultimately remained silent, her attention firmly fixed on her father.

Pressing on, Duncan outlined the next phase of their journey with unwavering focus. “Our next destination is Bartok’s ‘node,’ the final point of the ‘external barrier’ fashioned by the four gods. Completing the final mark there will allow the Vanished to circle back to the Leviathan Islands—the origin of our journey. Upon reaching that point, our explorations beyond known boundaries will draw to a close.”

With a sweeping gesture encompassing everyone at the table, Duncan lowered his voice to a whisper as he surveyed the faces of those who had shared this journey with him, finally settling his gaze on Nina.

Nina symbolized his initial connection to this world—the first ‘human’ he encountered and a pillar of humanity within this sanctuary.

Sensing the weight of Duncan’s thoughts, Nina broke the silence. “Once we reach that point, will you continue alone?”

Duncan’s response was resolute. “Yes.”

“And will this journey be fraught with peril? Is it a place far beyond our reach?” Nina sought clarification.

Duncan pondered her questions thoughtfully. “It’s not a matter of being ‘dangerous’ or ‘safe.’ It’s a task uniquely mine, beyond the understanding of others. I am venturing into a realm beyond the very edge of our world, a place so remote that even the gods hold no sway there—a distance immeasurable by any standard. Yes, it is exceedingly far.”

“Will you find your way back to us afterward?” Nina’s voice conveyed a blend of hope and concern as she reiterated her question.

“Yes, I will return,” Duncan affirmed with a certainty that left little room for doubt.

Nina’s expression registered surprise at his declaration, her brow furrowing slightly.

“Are you sure? You won’t leave us waiting in vain?” Her skepticism was evident in her tone.

“Absolutely. Should there come a time when you await my return, know that I would indeed come back, without fail,” Duncan promised, his assurance unwavering.

Nina’s expression grew more pensive, her brow furrowing as she absorbed Duncan’s assurances. It was at this moment that Morris, who had been

silent until now, posed a question that redirected the conversation: “What role do we play in all of this?”

Duncan turned to address Morris directly, his explanation deliberate and clear. “Once the Vanished embarks on its final journey, you and the crew will take charge of the Bright Star,” he instructed. “Agatha will utilize her abilities to create a ‘reflection’ of the Vanished, effectively linking it to the Bright Star. You will navigate following the Sea Song’s course, traveling from the domain of the Storm Goddess back to the vast expanse of the Boundless Sea.”

“Your return voyage will include stops at the city-states of Frost, Pland, and Wind Harbor. Additionally, you will rendezvous with Lawrence, who is currently stationed at Morpheus’s western frontier. With this arrangement, I will gain a comprehensive understanding of our world. Remain vigilant for my instructions; a significant event is imminent.”

Vanna reacted with a blend of curiosity and concern. “A significant event?”

Duncan’s response was measured yet profound. “The end of our world,” he declared. “I intend to orchestrate an orderly conclusion to our current existence before the underlying ‘mathematical machinery’ that sustains it completely unravels. It is crucial that we preserve the essence of our world beforehand.”

While the concept of a ‘mathematical machine’ may have been beyond the grasp of some, the mention of ‘the end of the world’ resonated deeply, sparking a shared moment of contemplation.

Shirley’s reaction punctuated the ensuing silence, a mix of astonishment and disbelief in her voice: “…Oh my…”

Yet, the rest of the group’s response was notably composed, a testament to their trust in Duncan.

Observing their reactions, Duncan couldn’t help but smile. “It seems you have a great deal of faith in me,” he remarked, appreciating the trust they had placed in him.

Vanna responded with a smile tinged with respect and gratitude. “After everything we’ve experienced in Pland, Frost, and Wind Harbor, how could we not trust you?” she pointed out. “You’ve had numerous opportunities to cause destruction, yet you’ve chosen preservation. If you were to propose something that seemed harmful, I would sooner doubt my own judgment than question yours.”

Duncan chuckled softly, recalling a past encounter. “Gomona would surely find it amusing. Weren’t you the one who greeted me with a flying chop when we first met?”

A hint of embarrassment colored Vanna’s cheeks. “You weren’t supposed to bring that up again,” she lightly admonished him.

Steering the conversation back to the broader picture, Duncan reassured them once more. “The ‘end’ of our current world is a necessary step toward the creation of a new one, a world where peace is everlasting. I’ve devised a plan to transition everything of value from this world to the next. You can trust in that.”

Driven by a blend of curiosity and concern, Shirley posed another question. “What comes after the end? Where do we stand in the aftermath? And what about you? How soon will this ‘new world’ you speak of come into being?”

Meeting her questioning gaze with a reassuring smile, Duncan responded softly, “Blink your eyes.”

Following his instruction, Shirley blinked, her expression one of puzzled anticipation.

“In the time it took you to blink, the new world would have arrived for you,” Duncan revealed, his voice carrying a promise of swift and profound change.

Chapter 818: Warmth and Cold

As the journey to the death node neared its conclusion, the monotonous grey-white expanse outside the ship began to reveal subtle changes. Thin black lines slowly materialized against the backdrop, hinting at structures emerging in the distance. These silhouettes grew more defined, gradually unfolding before the eyes of those aboard the Vanished and the members of the Bright Star's crew.

Duncan, having witnessed such sights on his voyages, found the scene unfolding before him to carry a unique sense of solitude and elongation this time around.

He stood silently at the front of the Vanished, patiently awaiting the end of their current leap through space, when he heard footsteps approaching from behind. Without the need to look back, he recognized the presence of his companion.

"Lucy," he spoke softly, acknowledging her without turning around, "we're nearing our destination."

"I'm aware," Lucretia replied as she joined Duncan at the ship's bow, gazing alongside him at the landscape gradually transforming in the distance. "This is the final node, isn't it? After this, we return to the Storm Goddess's haven. Every journey must come to an end."

Duncan exhaled a gentle sigh, a mix of resignation and sorrow in his voice. "I'm sorry that I must embark on the next part of our journey alone," he confessed, feeling a swell of emotions despite knowing he was merely

inhabiting an “avatar.” The complexity of his feelings in Lucretia’s presence left him questioning which of these emotions genuinely belonged to him or “Duncan Abnomar.”

Lucretia cut him off, her voice carrying a mix of warmth and seriousness, “You’ve fulfilled your promise by bringing me to the world’s end.”

She faced Duncan, her gaze steady and her demeanor composed, yet a hint of humor soon broke through as she laughed lightly. “What did you expect? That I would dissolve into tears, clinging to you to prevent you from embarking on what needs to be done? Or that I would lash out in anger, leaving you with a heavy heart as you set out on this crucial voyage? Did you think I would let my disappointment jeopardize the world’s hope at this critical moment?”

Duncan, faced with Lucretia’s laughter and resilience, found himself at a loss for words, managing only a resigned smile and a shrug in response.

Lucretia inhaled deeply, her smile serene as she locked eyes with Duncan. “I’m no longer a child, Papa. I can’t deter you from making your next move, nor can I offer a better solution to the problem at hand. The best I can do is smile in this moment… That’s something you taught me.”

Duncan responded with honesty, “I don’t recall teaching you that.”

“To smile at each goodbye,” Lucretia reminded him softly, cherishing the memory, “so if we never meet again, our last memory of each other will be one of happiness, not sorrow.”

Duncan remained silent, choosing not to mar the moment with questions about Lucretia and Tyrian’s final farewell to the captain of the Vanished—a century prior—when it set sail toward the eternal horizon.

After a brief pause, Lucretia raised her hand, her gaze locked firmly on Duncan.

Duncan, somewhat perplexed, looked at her. “What?”

“High-five,” Lucretia proposed simply.

“High-five?” Duncan echoed, his confusion evident in his slight frown.

“Promise me you’ll come back. Then, we high-five,” Lucretia explained, her voice steady and calm. She looked up at Duncan, standing tall at the bow against the backdrop of slowly shifting black lines in the distance. It seemed to her as if Duncan’s silhouette was about to merge into the changing patterns of light and shadow. For a moment, she was transported back to a sun-bleached afternoon at the dock, with her father standing silent and statuesque at the plank to the Vanished.

“High-five. Promise me and my brother you’ll return safely.” Those were the words she had uttered back then.

Back when she was much younger, not yet known as the “sea witch,” she couldn’t recall whether she had been smiling at that moment—likely not, as she wasn’t as emotionally resilient and seasoned as she is now.

In her memory, Duncan eventually turned and walked away in silence.

But the warm touch and the sound of their palms meeting snapped Lucretia back to the present. She saw her father smiling, his hand enveloping hers in a reassuring gesture, reminiscent of the farewells he offered each time he departed from their home during her and her brother’s childhood.

Suddenly, the dark silhouette in the distance swelled, filling their entire field of vision outside the Vanished and the Bright Star. The grey-white backdrop seemed to silently collapse, and a distorted voice echoed in everyone’s mind: “…jump… stop.”

Before Lucretia and Duncan unfolded a vast, colorless wilderness, a landscape devoid of any hues except for shades of black, white, and grey. There were no shores, no seas, only a barren expanse where black and white

grass grew untamed, waving in the wind in eerie silence, like the quiet waves of death.

The Vanished and the Bright Star sailed above these undulating grasses, silently traversing this desolate wilderness under the cloak of perpetual night.

…

The night appeared endless as if the sun would never rise again.

Frem stood beside the roaring bonfire on the Ark of the Flame Bearers, his gaze wandering back towards the path they had traveled from, towards the fringes of civilization. Yet, all he could see was boundless darkness, with the World's Creation emitting a cold, pale glow over the sea, reflecting like a mirror. It seemed as if from the distant past to the far future, the world had always been ensconced in this somber state.

He turned his attention back to the bonfire, continuing his prayers in its flickering light.

The cold northern winds whispered secrets in his ear, mingling with the deep, mechanical groans from within the ark. Occasionally, the distant sounds of ice shattering or continuous thunderous roars broke the silence—ominous noises made by the ark's ice-breaking prow as it navigated through the ice-laden waters.

The Ark of the Flame Bearers ventured further north, having passed the series of "northern city-states," including Frost, and now entered what was once deemed the "end of civilization": the frigid ocean.

In this icy realm, the vast expanse of the sea was replaced by endless layers of ice that stretched into the darkness. Mist rose from the depths of these ice fields, reaching up to meld with the sky. Illuminated by the enigmatic light of the World's Creation, the entire landscape was bathed in a uniform, eerie

silver glow that, paradoxically, seemed to shimmer with a sort of “brightness.”

After what felt like an eternity immersed in prayer, Frem opened his eyes, a frown creasing his brow as if he’d sensed an anomaly. Shadows, indistinct and fleeting, separated from the surrounding darkness, moving toward the great bonfire at the forefront.

As the figure representing historical continuity merged into the flames, Frem gave a subtle nod and summoned an attendant of the Flame Bearers, who was always on standby nearby. He whispered a set of instructions to the attendant, who then departed to carry them out. Before long, deep, mechanical sounds resonated from within the Ark of the Flame Bearers. This feat of engineering marvel began to adjust its trajectory with precision, simultaneously recalibrating its ice-breaking mechanism to continue its voyage deeper into the ice fields. Amidst the sound of ice being shattered, a series of disconcerting, sharp noises could also be heard.

A priestess, dressed in a black robe and veil, quickly approached Frem next to the bonfire. “Your Holiness, we’ve suffered a malfunction in one of the transmission shafts within the ice-breaking mechanism,” she reported urgently.

“Is it still operational?” Frem inquired.

“The mechanism’s efficiency has decreased by thirty percent, but it remains functional,” the priestess responded promptly. “However, the chief mechanical priest has warned that the failure of the initial transmission shaft is likely to set off a domino effect. There’s a risk that additional shafts may fail within the next five to seven days, potentially rendering the ice-breaking mechanism inoperative.”

Frem shook his head slowly, his response measured. “That’s acceptable for now. The ice-breaking enhancement was always meant to be a temporary

measure. This vessel wasn’t originally designed for ice navigation,” he explained, displaying a calm demeanor. “Don’t worry. We’re nearing our destination.”

The priestess glanced towards the great bonfire, a beacon in their icy surroundings. “Is the ‘direction’ given by the Lord directly ahead?”

“Yes,” Frem confirmed with a gentle nod. “The Lord revealed to me through the vision in the flames that we are approaching a pivotal moment in the real dimension’s historical continuum. Transporting these critical archival documents to this location is essential for leaving ‘traces.’ Though the Lord’s guidance has grown increasingly indistinct, and the exact nature of these ‘traces’ remains unclear to me, their significance is undeniable.”

The priestess offered no further questions. Instead, she bowed her head in devout prayer before the great bonfire. While she harbored no expectation of receiving divine communication—as such messages had long been exclusive to the Pope—prayer had ingrained itself into the daily routine of the clergy, becoming a source of comfort even in the absence of direct responses.

The biting cold of the ice sea, capable of penetrating to the bone, was relentless. Despite this, the clergy and crew aboard the ark found themselves gradually acclimating to the frigid conditions. Those who had initially fallen ill due to the cold were beginning to recover, a small yet positive development in their challenging journey.

Concluding her prayer, the priestess rose, and the cold wind was a sharp reminder of their harsh environment. “I’ll inform the engineering team to maximize the operational lifespan of the ice-breaking mechanism. We need to keep those hydraulic hammers active until we reach the ‘focal point.’ Should the mechanism fail entirely, we’ll resort to explosives. We’ve prepared a substantial stockpile for such an eventuality.”

Frem acknowledged her plan with a slight nod.

The priestess offered a respectful bow before departing. Yet, she paused for a moment to cast another glance at the great bonfire, its flames casting more shadows than warmth. “This fire is so cold.”

Chapter 819: The Stagnant Land of the Dead

In an expansive wasteland where the colors black, white, and gray dominated the landscape, a relentless and bone-chilling wind swept across the terrain without pause. The grass moved in waves, and the surrounding plants, devoid of any color other than black and white, swayed without life in the gusts. Occasionally, small, faint lights would emerge from the grass, floating and drifting above this desolate expanse like lost souls wandering in a forgotten realm of the dead.

This entire land was bathed in a dim, perpetual twilight, under a sky that was clear of fog or clouds, yet filled with swirling, murky patches of color that danced endlessly.

The Vanished and the Bright Star moved silently through this desolate expanse. This bizarre occurrence defied explanation, so Lucretia dispatched two toys from the ship to explore the “land” beyond. They confirmed that beneath the undulating grass was indeed solid ground. Yet, both vessels continued to glide over this vast terrain, their hulls cutting through the earth as though they were navigating waters, blurring the line between the concepts of “sea” and “wilderness.”

At Duncan’s behest, both ships slowed their pace, navigating carefully under the never-ending night sky. Shirley ascended to the scout’s nest atop the mast, scanning the horizon, yet all she could see was the endless

wilderness. The land was flat, save for slight undulations, with no structures or notable landmarks in sight—not even the smallest hill.

After a time of aimless journeying, the ships gradually came to a halt, as if marooned in this boundless and uninterrupted wasteland.

“Given the unusual circumstances we faced at the ‘Island of Ashes’ previously, we must tread carefully this time,” Duncan addressed his crew gravely after assembling them on the deck. “We mustn’t leave the ship without due caution. Right now, understanding the ‘rules’ of this ‘Dead Wilderness’ is paramount.”

“We should seek advice from an expert,” Morris interjected promptly. “Miss Agatha might have insights into the realm of the dead…”

No sooner had the aged scholar spoken than a shadowy figure materialized on the deck, and Agatha’s voice, carrying a mysterious and otherworldly tremble, filled the air: “I’m attempting to decipher our current predicament, though it may be quite complex.”

She took a brief pause, seemingly gathering her thoughts, and then proceeded to elucidate, “According to ancient texts, those who find themselves in the Dead Wilderness are set upon a ‘Path of No Return’ that winds through the wilderness. This path stretches indefinitely, with only one direction to follow. Those who have passed away walk this path, gradually losing memories of their earthly lives. Along the way, they will meet the ‘Gatekeepers,’ messengers who guide the deceased further into the realm of the dead.”

“The Gatekeepers are tasked with leading the deceased along unseen pathways, traversing the entire wilderness in a mere moment to arrive at the heart of the realm of the dead—a place marked by a colossal gate. It is here that the departed glimpse the silhouette of Bartok guarding the entrance. Under its watchful presence, they shed all earthly burdens and impurities,

entering through the gate in a state of purity, to embrace eternal peace," Agatha detailed the beliefs of the death church.

In this belief system, unlike what Duncan was accustomed to, there was no notion of reincarnation. Death marked a final transition into perpetual rest, not a cycle of return to the living world.

This revelation piqued Shirley's interest. "So, does this mean that everyone just… goes to sleep behind that gate after they die? But what if there's no more room? People continue to die, after all…"

As Shirley pondered out loud, Alice, who had just descended from the helm, joined in the speculation with a soft voice, "Wouldn't that make it crowded? Are they piled on top of each other as they sleep?"

Shirley, leaning closer to Alice, whispered a humorous theory, "Maybe they sleep standing up, packed tightly like bamboo skewers, stacking vertically until there's no more space, and then they start stacking horizontally on top, creating layers—one horizontal, then another vertical, and so forth…"

"But wouldn't the ones at the bottom feel crushed by the weight?" Alice pondered.

"No, I've heard that the dead don't weigh anything…" Shirley answered.

As the conversation between Shirley and Alice took a turn into the absurd, Duncan, noticing the increasingly bizarre atmosphere, felt compelled to intervene. "Ahem… perhaps you could keep this discussion between yourselves."

Shirley quickly recoiled, nodding in understanding, "Oh, right…"

Duncan redirected the conversation back to Agatha. "You mentioned that our situation is 'somewhat complicated'… Could you elaborate?"

Agatha affirmed, “To put it simply, according to the sacred texts, outsiders require a ‘passage’ and ‘guidance’ to meet the god of death. However, it appears that this guiding mechanism has faltered.”

Duncan’s frown deepened as he grasped the implications.

Lucretia and Morris, standing by, showed signs of realization as well. Morris, pipe in mouth, expressed concern, “It seems the world’s death mechanism has ceased to function…”

“Indeed, with the disappearance of the death mechanism, the ‘Gatekeepers’ that usher souls across the Dead Wilderness are absent as well,” Agatha continued with a solemn tone, her gaze drifting towards the endless wilderness beyond the ship. “Without the deceased to initiate the ‘Path of No Return’ and the presence of ‘Gatekeepers,’ what remains is merely this wilderness. And although the giant gate and the lord of death theoretically reside at the center of this realm, reaching it without the proper guidance is an impossibility.”

Nina, who had been silently absorbing the conversation with rapt attention, suddenly found herself unable to contain her curiosity any longer. Her eyes widened as she alternated her gaze between Duncan and Agatha, before finally voicing her thoughts, “Do we really need specific conditions like ‘paths’ and ‘guidance’? Isn’t there some other way we could approach this? Perhaps some kind of ritual or something along those lines…”

Agatha responded with a gentle shake of her head, conveying a sense of regret. “I’m afraid there aren’t alternative paths available. Symbolism plays a vital role when it comes to matters involving the gods. It’s about recreating specific events according to very precise rules. And given the unique nature of the realm governed by the god of death, the regulations here are even more stringent than in other domains. This is essential to maintain a clear separation between the realms of the living and the dead.”

She paused, a complex expression crossing her face as she continued, “At least, that was the case before the death mechanism vanished from our world.”

Breaking the ensuing silence, Vanna chimed in with a thought-provoking question, “So, if we were to find a ‘deceased’ person, could it potentially reactivate the guiding mechanism here and open up the pathway to the grand gate guarded by Bartok?”

Agatha replied cautiously, confirming Vanna’s theory based on her understanding of the sacred texts. “That’s one interpretation, yes. But it’s not guaranteed to be straightforward. The scriptures speak of the world as it was in ‘normal’ times, and much has changed since then. Even the gods… have been altered into forms beyond their own recognition.”

Vanna nodded, seeing a potential direction in Agatha’s words. “It gives us something to work with, at least. It’s a starting point, better than aimlessly wandering this wilderness.”

However, Morris quickly highlighted a significant obstacle to this theory, his voice muffled slightly by his pipe. “The real challenge is finding a deceased person now that the concept of ‘death’ seems to have been erased from the world.”

This remark cast a strange pause over the group, prompting uneasy glances among the crew.

Attention turned to Agatha, who promptly clarified her position with a raised hand, “Don’t look at me. In the strictest sense, I’m not ‘dead.’ I exist merely as a fading shadow. I never truly ‘lived’ in the conventional sense, so I can’t be considered ‘dead.’”

Then, as eyes shifted to Vanna, she quickly dismissed the notion, “And I’m not a valid candidate either, right? Yes, I died once, but was revived. My

continued existence has been affirmed by the captain, so I don't fit the criteria of being truly deceased…"

She trailed off, adding with a note of uncertainty, "At least, not in the full sense of the word?"

"I'm out of the question too—I've become a shadow demon after being reborn," Shirley quickly asserted, noticing the gaze of the group turning her way. She waved off the speculation, "Even though I've died once, the current me, being reborn, means I'm beyond the reach of Bartok's 'Gatekeeper'…"

Duncan surveyed his crew, his expression turning thoughtful as he stroked his chin, a hint of bemusement in his voice. "It's rather odd, isn't it? That on this ship, it seems we're devoid of both the living and the dead as traditionally defined…"

While musing aloud, Duncan's gaze inadvertently fell upon Morris, who was engaged in an unusual activity. The old man was holding an unlit pipe in one hand and a screwdriver in the other, meticulously adjusting something at the back of his head with a series of mechanical clicks.

Catching the captain's inquisitive look, Morris hurriedly tucked the screwdriver away, a faint buzzing of springs emanating from his chest. "Apologies for the racket—seems a screw's gone loose in my noggin," he explained, almost casually.

A hush fell over the assembled group on the deck, each member exchanging silent glances that spoke volumes of their shared bewilderment.

Amidst this contemplative silence, Alice, emerging from a moment of distraction, leaned closer to Shirley and whispered, her mind still tangled in their previous musings, "…Could it be that they are like how Sailor sleeps, by hanging…"

Shirley, caught off guard by the sudden return to a seemingly abandoned line of discussion from earlier, replied incredulously, “Are you still on that topic? We’ve moved on countless times since then…”

Her voice trailed off as a thought struck the demon girl, “Wait, who did you just bring up?”

“Sailor, he likes to pretend to be sleeping by hanging,” Alice clarified, unfazed.

Slowly, Shirley turned her attention back to Duncan, a new line of inquiry forming in her mind. “Speaking of which… why hasn’t that mummy joined us yet?”

“He’s likely below deck at this moment, probably shirking his duties again,” Duncan acknowledged, his brow furrowing at the realization. “But that brings us to another question… Can Anomaly 077 be considered ‘deceased’ in the conventional sense? Somehow, his ‘death’ seems less genuine than that of others here.”

His gaze lingered thoughtfully on Agatha, Vanna, and Shirley, each embodying their unique state of being between life and death.

Sensing the situation’s oddity, Shirley remarked, “Captain, you have an unusual way of putting things…”

To which Duncan responded, his eyes widening in mock surprise, “Isn’t the nature of our entire conversation unusually strange?”

Chapter 820: Forgery

In theory, Anomaly 077 didn’t conform to the traditional definition of a deceased being. Despite this, the crew unanimously agreed that it was worth an attempt – that they should at least try.

Therefore, approximately twelve minutes later, Sailor found himself unexpectedly jolted from his slumber in a secluded corner of the lower deck by a sudden surge of frantic and disorderly footsteps. As he opened his eyes, the sight that greeted him was the captain, urgently leading the entire crew in his direction. Before Sailor had a chance to gather his thoughts, Vanna swiftly approached and, grabbing him by the collar, lifted him off the ground.

Witnessing such an unprecedented scenario, Sailor experienced a chill of fear and anticipation run through him as he caught the eager and intense gazes of his shipmates. Attempting to retreat, he stammered, “I… I was merely seeking a quiet spot to rest, surely that doesn’t breach any crew regulations… And even if it somehow does, you can’t all possibly be thinking of reprimanding me through physical means, can you?”

“Quit your feigning; you’re incapable of sleep anyway,” Duncan emerged from the throng, scrutinizing Anomaly 077 closely, “There’s a matter of utmost importance that requires your attention.”

“A matter of utmost importance?” Sailor, puzzled, swiftly straightened his attire and adjusted his stance, alert to Vanna’s impending actions (he remained apprehensive that the formidable and attractive woman might unintentionally inflict harm on him with a mere touch) and inquired with

curiosity, “What matter could that be? Haven’t we just reached the domain of the God of Death? Are we considering retreat already?”

Duncan dismissed the question with a gesture, cutting directly to the core of the issue: “The reason is precisely because we’ve arrived at the domain of the God of Death – we now necessitate a deceased individual to attempt to awaken the guide here.”

Confounded, Sailor needed a moment to digest this information, then, turning his bewildered gaze towards Dog in the corner, he uttered, “… What?”

“In simpler terms, due to the ‘decay’ affecting the God of Death, the process governing death in the mortal realm has ceased. Consequently, with the cessation of this process, no new deceased are arriving in this barren landscape, leading to the absence of both the gatekeeper and the Path of No Return,” Dog elucidated with patience, despite being unclear why he was the one providing the explanation, “The ‘entrance’ to the God of Death’s realm is concealed within a location that can only be accessed through a specific ‘guidance ritual’. Our current objective is to reawaken the gatekeeper here – to put it bluntly, we require a deceased individual.”

With a slightly better understanding, Sailor paused for a moment of silent contemplation before hesitantly pointing towards himself and stating, somewhat confusedly: “I’m not entirely deceased, though… although it’s true that I’ve been heading in that direction. Why not consider Lady Agatha for this task? She appears to be more deceased than I am, considering I still possess some physical form, whereas her soul seems even more diminished…”

“We’ve deliberated over it, and concluded that neither Agatha, Vanna, nor Shirley meet the necessary criteria,” Morris interjected with a sigh, his gaze fixed on the somewhat desiccated figure before him with a mixture of

emotions, “However, it seems you don’t quite meet the criteria either – while you are technically a corpse, there are many like you who remain active in the mortal world today. Such ‘undead’ beings appear incapable of drawing the ‘gatekeeper’s’ notice.”

“Given the current situation, it’s uncertain whether the ‘gatekeeper’ of the realm of death still exists,” Sailor commented with a shrug. “They might have vanished along with the ‘decay’ that affected Bartok. After all, these ‘gatekeepers’ are fundamentally intertwined with the death mechanism itself…”

Morris wore a look of contemplation, his brow furrowed in thought, when Duncan’s attention was drawn to a shadow on the wall that appeared to tremble slightly. With curiosity sparking in his eyes, he inquired, “Agatha? Is something the matter?”

Breaking the lingering silence, Agatha proposed, “I was wondering… perhaps we could simulate a state of death using ‘Sailor’ as a model to determine if the ‘gatekeeper’ of this realm still lingers among us. It might just work.”

Duncan, caught off guard, questioned, “…You believe that’s possible?”

“I once served as a ‘gatekeeper,’ albeit in the realm of the living. However, there’s a sort of ‘mirror’ effect between the gatekeepers of the living and those of the dead, reflecting the ‘symmetry’ inherent to the God of Death,” Agatha elaborated. “During my training, which remains vivid in my memory, I learned how to ‘communicate’ with the gatekeepers of the dead world once a soul departs its mortal coil. These ‘conversations’ revealed that the judgments of the ‘other side’s gatekeepers’ concerning the deceased are not infallible. At times, they mistakenly linger around those who are not yet dead, and such ‘errors’… can be manipulated.”

Shirley, catching up with the conversation, expressed her concern: “Wait, is that even permissible? It sounds rather dark!”

“Absolutely not, it’s blasphemous,” Agatha responded with a casual shrug. “To deceive the emissary of divinity and disrupt the balance of life and death, to the extent of beckoning death itself – ordinarily, such acts would merit a death sentence.”

Shirley quickly interjected with a question: “I’m curious, for a priest of death, would such a sentence be considered a promotion or a dismissal…”

Duncan gestured for Shirley to hold her thoughts, silencing her speculative query (despite having pondered it himself), and then directed his gaze towards Agatha: “Is this really okay?”

“It’s fine. Given that the very fabric of life and death has unraveled, along with the old doctrines and the authority they once held… who besides me even remembers them?” Agatha mused, her shadow casting a seemingly rueful smile in the flickering light, “Besides, no one is left to pass such a sentence on me.”

After a brief pause, observing the indistinct shadow, Duncan nodded in agreement: “Alright, let’s proceed. What are our first steps?”

“Firstly, we must distance ourselves from the Vanished. Aboard this vessel, not even the ‘gatekeeper’s’ gaze can pierce through,” Agatha stated promptly. “Next, we require ‘Sailor’s’ cooperation. I will transform him into the likeness of a ‘deceased,’ though he need not do anything except follow my guidance. And finally… this is for Sailor.”

Her attention then shifted to Anomaly 077, who was nearby: “You must remember, regardless of what appears before you, do not follow it – the allure of the gatekeeper’s beckoning is irresistible to the deceased. Even

though you aren’t truly dead and possess the capacity to resist, it will undoubtedly be a formidable challenge.”

“Rest assured, I won’t be lured away,” Anomaly 077 declared with confidence, patting his chest for emphasis, “I’ve found my place here on the Vanished; there’s no reason for me to leave it…”

“But what if, at the journey’s end along the Path of No Return, you encounter the crew of the Sea Song?” Agatha posed the question with a serene tone. “What if you come face to face with the captain of the Sea Song?”

The atmosphere became noticeably more somber at her inquiry.

Sailor, too, fell into silence, the figure of the desiccated corpse remaining motionless. However, just as Duncan anticipated a moment of doubt, Sailor instead shook his head with even greater resolve, stating, “I won’t be swayed to follow her.”

“Are you certain? We must treat this with utmost seriousness,” Agatha pressed further for assurance.

“I’m certain,” Sailor affirmed with a grin, an air of confidence about him, “Captain Caraline entrusted me with a message for the city-state, along with the navigation course – she would never expect me to follow her. That’s not what she would have wanted.”

“…Very well, then we have no issue.” Agatha acknowledged with a nod.

Amidst the chaotic whisper of the cold wind under the night sky, the black and white tall grasses danced in the wind. A paper boat descended gracefully from the Vanished, coming to rest on the barren ground. Here, Duncan was the first to disembark, stepping onto the desolate terrain of the realm of death.

Following him, Agatha's indistinct silhouette seemed to barely touch down as she "floated" from the ship, landing gracefully beside him.

Sailor was the last to leave the ship – his exit less graceful, resulting in a tumble that produced an odd crack from his hip upon landing.

"Damn… I really should have considered metal joints before embarking on this journey," Sailor grumbled, readjusting his dislocated joint before limping over, "Is this the place? What comes next?"

Agatha glanced back at the small boat, now silent among the wild grass, with only Lucretia's silhouette visible on it. The rest of the crew remained on the Vanished, a precaution to avoid a recurrence of the "Island of Ashes" incident.

Turning her attention to their surroundings, Agatha pointed to a specific spot: "Simple, just lie down here."

Sailor, without any hesitation or objection, complied and lay down in the designated spot, indifferent to the chill of the ground as the tall black and white grasses enveloped him.

"…This feels like my own funeral," Sailor commented, a tinge of somberness in his voice, "These grasses encircling me, they're like the walls of a coffin."

Agatha didn't acknowledge Sailor's musings.

After ensuring he was positioned correctly, she took a moment to center herself, focusing her energy. Gradually, her initially indistinct and ghostly figure began to gain clarity.

A faint green glow emerged within her, momentarily casting a light upon her form, transforming her from a mere shadowy presence into a semi-transparent, spectral being. Though still ethereal, she now appeared capable of performing the next "ritual".

A staff, conjured from the depths of her memory, materialized in her hand.

“…This feels oddly familiar,” Agatha murmured to herself, looking at the staff with a mixture of nostalgia and resolve. She then commenced circling Sailor, her staff lightly touching the ground as she moved.

As Agatha traced her path along the ground, pale flames ignited from the lines she drew, ascending to form a triangular shape against the monochrome backdrop of the black, white, and gray terrain.

Sailor, positioned at the heart of the triangle, became enveloped in a silence born of apprehension, his anticipation rendering him still as he braced for the imminent proceedings.

With deliberate care, Agatha commenced the inscription of numerous arcane runes encircling the triangle. Each symbol was crafted with precision, marking a ritual she hadn’t performed in ages.

“From this point forward, remain silent and avoid wandering eyes; the dead neither speak nor gaze upon the world around them. You might perceive someone calling your name or witness strange lights before you, yet these are mere deceptions, unworthy of your focus,” Agatha paused momentarily, standing over Sailor’s prone form at the triangle’s epicenter, her gaze fixed upon the desiccated figure, “Eventually, a twilight-like glow, the sole ‘hue’ amidst this realm of death, will emerge. Subsequently, the ‘gatekeeper’ of this domain shall make an appearance. Heed my instructions carefully; do not succumb to his allure – leave the negotiations to the captain and myself.”

Chapter 821: The Guide

Sailor lay perfectly still and silent, camouflaged among the contrasting hues of the tall, black and white grass, convincing himself he had become indistinguishable from a lifeless body.

The wind, chaotic and unyielding, whipped through the wild grass, creating waves that seemed alive. Within this tumult, faint sounds began to emerge, weaving through the air like distant whispers, subdued conversations, and the ghostly strains of music, creating an otherworldly symphony.

Embracing the tranquility associated with death, Sailor shut his eyes, allowing the serene embrace of the imagined afterlife to envelop him amidst the boundless wilderness.

With a staff in hand, Agatha moved around Sailor in a deliberate pattern, tracing a circle around him thrice. With each step she took, runes etched into the earth below her glowed, casting an eerie light. Pausing by Sailor's head, she planted her staff into the ground and extended her arms wide as if to welcome or invoke something unseen.

Suddenly, the wind intensified, carrying clearer and more distinct sounds. Duncan, observing the scene, anticipated the awakening of the "gatekeeper" of this realm. However, as abruptly as it had risen, the wind calmed, and the sounds faded into silence.

"…Hmm?" Agatha opened her eyes, a look of perplexity crossing her face, her brow knitting together in concern.

“What’s happening?” Duncan inquired, his curiosity piqued by the unexpected turn of events.

Sailor, still lying on the ground, cautiously opened his eyes, sensing that the ritual might not be proceeding as planned. He remembered Agatha’s earlier instructions to remain silent and immobile, so he communicated his confusion and concern solely through his eyes, daring not to move or speak.

Agatha, troubled, revealed, “At the final moment when we should have established a connection, I felt the presence of the realm’s ‘gatekeepers’. Yet, they didn’t engage with us; they simply departed.”

She continued, clarifying their original intent, “Our aim wasn’t just to be noticed. We needed the ‘gatekeeper’ of this side to reveal themselves. Even if they detected the feigned death, it should have prompted them to appear more swiftly, as a simulated demise is a grave offense, perhaps even more so than an actual death.”

Understanding the stakes, Duncan then realized the implications: “Ah, so our actions could actually provoke these ‘gatekeepers’?”

“Yes,” Agatha affirmed, “Should they discover our ruse, their fury would be immense.”

Duncan, taken aback, remarked, “You hadn’t mentioned this risk before.”

Agatha responded with a nonchalant shrug, “As long as we remain undetected, there’s no issue. But if discovered, I admit, there’s little I could do. I might not be able to confront them, but I am adept at escaping. Should it come to it, negotiating with the ‘gatekeepers’ is feasible. They’re reasonable beings who usually can be appeased after an initial fight.”

Now slightly wary, Duncan sensed that the situation was not as straightforward as he had initially believed.

Yet, without dwelling on his reservations, he redirected his attention to the immediate issue: the apparent indifference of the ‘gatekeeper’ to their staged scenario of death.

Agatha’s expression conveyed her resolve as she paused, deep in thought. Then, her gaze shifted decisively towards Sailor, and she broke the silence with a sense of urgency: “I’ll attempt the ritual once more. As soon as it concludes, you need to spring to your feet and dash back to our small boat as swiftly as you can—this action will disrupt the ‘passage’. Remember, do not look back under any circumstances.”

Sailor, clearly anxious, could only respond with a wandering gaze, prompting Agatha to seek a simpler form of communication: “I need clarity. Just nod or shake your head slightly.”

After a brief hesitation, Sailor’s head began to sway as if to signal ‘no’, yet he halted midway and instead offered a subtle nod.

“Alright, I’ll take that as your agreement. Remain still; I’m about to restart the process.”

With that, Agatha grasped the combat staff that had emerged from the depths of her memory. Once again, she ignited the pale flames at her feet, reactivating the enigmatic runes etched into the earth.

As the ritual recommenced, the wind whipped up around them, carrying whispers and murmurs through the air. Agatha successfully reestablished the “passage,” and even Duncan felt the presence of “them” once more.

At the ritual’s climax, Agatha forcefully planted the staff into the ground and commanded, “Now – get up!”

Sailor, prepared for this moment, sprang up with urgency, vaulting over the encircling flames, and sprinted towards the origami boat nearby.

This sudden movement from the “deceased” Sailor disrupted the ritual, tearing through the “passage” and revealing a realm that lay concealed within a deeper layer of reality to Duncan.

The flames surged upwards, and the triangular rune array left by Agatha burst into a brilliant light. Then, above the triangle, the air itself seemed to fracture silently, a sliver of twilight emerging from this crack—a rapid expansion that painted the ascending flames with a twilight glow.

Through this widening breach, Duncan caught sight of an unusually tall figure cloaked in black. Contrary to Agatha’s predictions, the figure showed no signs of anger but merely observed the scene quietly before turning away.

Confused, Duncan turned to Agatha, who was visibly taken aback. She called out to the departing “gatekeeper” in frustration, “Wait! Doesn’t this violation of the rules concern you? The faking of death, the deliberate sabotage of the guiding passage—address this issue!”

But the figure continued to walk away, seemingly indifferent to her protests. As it departed, the crack in the sky began to seal shut.

Stunned yet determined, Agatha was about to take matters into her own hands and force the passage open to pursue when suddenly, dry, claw-like hands emerged at the edge of the closing gap. These hands grasped the edges of the crack, holding it ajar and then forcefully widening it again as the sound of breaking glass filled the air, signifying the forcible reopening of the passage.

Emerging from the other side of the crack was a figure, a “gatekeeper” draped in a robe as dark as the deepest night. Its hood was so deep that it shrouded its face entirely, leaving only two dimly glowing yellow eyes visible, flickering with an eerie light akin to fire beneath the shadow of the hood. The gatekeeper leaned forward, and from beneath the hood came a

voice, gravelly and deep, as though it were echoing up from the depths of the earth itself, uttering a single command: “Come.”

With that terse, chilling command, the crack, resembling shattered glass, disintegrated without a sound.

Simultaneously, the morose landscape that Duncan had been staring at—the embodiment of night within the wilderness—crumbled away. The shroud of perpetual darkness that had enveloped the realm of the dead lifted, unveiling the soft luminescence of twilight. The monochrome grass of the wilderness, unnamed and untouched, began to sway gently in the twilight breeze, revealing a pathway that extended endlessly into the horizon as if it were a bridge between the heavens and the earth itself.

The towering “gatekeeper” stood silently upon this newly revealed path, immovable and solemn as if it were part of the landscape itself.

Duncan’s gaze momentarily drifted back towards the Lost and the Dazzling Stars, the two ships now appearing as ghostly, frozen silhouettes in the distance, bathed on one side by the twilight glow. Despite the newfound light, the edge of the wilderness seemed to retain a shadow of its former nocturnal veil.

Turning his attention forward once more, Duncan observed the silent gatekeeper breaking the stillness of the moment, issuing another brief command: “Go.”

With that, the figure began to stride along the path, prompting Duncan and Agatha to exchange a glance before hurriedly following.

“The situation is somewhat perplexing,” Agatha whispered to Duncan as they walked, her voice tinged with unease. “The gatekeepers I recall… the ones from my memories, they don’t behave like this. Their presence feels off… Their actions and mannerisms are different.”

“The one who walked away earlier was strange as well,” Duncan added casually. “At least this one has chosen to appear and guide us. That’s something, given that we’ve reached a ‘deeper place.’”

“That’s precisely why it’s strange,” Agatha replied, her brow furrowed in thought. “The gatekeepers should easily recognize that we’re not ‘dead.’ Typically, they would inquire or negotiate before leading us anywhere… Yet, this one simply began guiding us. It’s as if he was expecting us…”

Duncan nodded, finding her observation logical. “Why not ask him?”

After a brief hesitation, Agatha looked up towards the tall figure, which had slowed its pace ahead of them. “Are you specifically waiting for us here?” she inquired.

The towering figure remained silent, offering no response as if Agatha’s question had fallen on deaf ears.

Unwavering in her determination, Agatha raised her voice after a brief pause, seeking clarity: “Do you recognize us? Can you see that we are not actually deceased?”

The imposing figure ahead halted momentarily, releasing a noncommittal grunt that sounded like “Hmm.”

Turning towards Duncan with a mix of confusion and resignation, Agatha speculated, “It seems this gatekeeper may simply be uninterested in our state.”

Duncan remained silent, absorbing Agatha’s observation. After a moment of contemplation, he directed a question at the gatekeeper: “Earlier, we encountered another gatekeeper who disregarded us and departed. There were mentions of others as well. Where have they gone?”

To their astonishment, the gatekeeper ceased walking, breaking his silence with a word that resonated deeply: “Funeral.”

Puzzled, Duncan queried further, “A funeral? Are you implying that the other gatekeepers have gathered for a funeral?”

“Yes,” came the terse reply.

“Whose funeral could it be?” Agatha inquired, driven by a mix of curiosity and concern.

“The Death God’s,” the gatekeeper responded, turning to face them. Under the shadow of his hood, the dull yellow glow of his eyes seemed to burn with a quiet intensity.

“The Death God is dead,” he declared, a statement that hung in the air with a weight that seemed to shift the very atmosphere around them.

Chapter 822: The Worlds Last Cooling

In a world where deities and ancient evils once roamed, their demise had become a part of history so profound it seemed almost tangible. Duncan had always been aware that not only the Death God but also the Storm Goddess, the Eternal Flame, the God of Wisdom, and every other ancient god and evil entity—whether they had left their mark in the annals of history or faded into oblivion—were long gone. This knowledge wasn't new to him; every ancient ruler and deity had perished.

This cataclysmic event, known as the Great Annihilation, occurred well before the world as they knew it turned into a wasteland of scorching chaos and ash. On that fateful day, when thousands of worlds collapsed, all gods met their end, leaving behind nothing but their decaying remains—a mere echo of the old world's inertia.

However, when the towering gatekeeper solemnly announced, "The Death God is dead," Duncan realized with a jolt that the reference wasn't to the historical extinction he was familiar with. It signified a recent occurrence, a new kind of end.

Agatha, standing beside Duncan, also grasped the gravity of the situation. Her initial confusion quickly transformed into sheer astonishment. "What happened?"

…

The world was undergoing a chilling transformation, and it wasn’t just the physical temperature that was dropping. An essential vitality, akin to the foundational essence of the mortal realm, was gradually fading away. It felt as if the world was exhaling its last breath, signaling the imminent demise of an era.

The undead began to roam the streets freely. The cold flames that once combated the cold were now ineffective against the encroaching frost that enveloped the mortal world. The seas had turned stagnant, and memories of the past were either vanishing or morphing into unrecognizable, fragmented echoes.

From the thriving trading city of Pland, through the cold landscapes of Frost, to the elven island of Wind Harbor, from scientific Mok to the shattered archipelagos of the Eastern Seas, a palpable sense of “cooling” and “alienation” was spreading. Like an unstoppable dark force, it was gradually extinguishing every last gleam of civilization.

Tyrian made his way to the tallest lighthouse in the southeastern region of Frost. From its observation deck, he gazed out at the dark sea stretching towards the city-state. A large fleet, bathed in sunlight, was approaching. The cargo ships, heavy with oil, cloth, and grain, docked at the pier. In the darkness, massive loading machines buzzed into action, transferring goods from the ships to the shore.

At the docks, the undead sailors of the Mist Fleet were busily engaged, outnumbered now by even more of their “kindred” from recent days. Oblivious to death, these corpses manned the machinery, ensuring the city continued to function as per the directives of City Hall.

Beyond, in the city district, tall chimneys and the bright lights of factory platforms stood out. The power plants hummed with activity, steam hubs vibrated with energy, and vast pipes, like veins, extended from the factories

into the city. They supplied power and protection to the inhabitants, a semblance of normalcy in a world growing increasingly cold.

Yet, within those factories, the massive steam cores had cooled. No catalyst could reignite the warmth from the flames within their chambers. Despite this, the cold reactors continued to hiss, steam flowed without pause, and the pipes throbbed with what seemed like relentless power.

The city's vitality, metaphorically its "breath" and "blood," continued to pulse through its vast network of pipes without pause. Despite the ominous changes happening elsewhere, the city's gas lamps still cast their bright glow, factories buzzed with activity, machinery churned tirelessly, and guardians roamed the streets. These sentinels were ever-vigilant for supernatural disturbances that defied the natural laws, while sheriffs kept order under the cloak of night, aiding those in need and addressing the growing incidents affecting public safety.

The semblance of normalcy prevailed; the city's heartbeat of civilization had not yet dimmed. Yet, Tyrian sensed an unsettling shift in the atmosphere—a cold, faintly decayed scent as if emerging from the city's very foundation, from the darkest depths of the Boundless Sea, carried by every gust of wind, permeating every sliver of sky, and clinging to every particle of dust.

He could feel the world teetering on the brink of a catastrophic decline, a sensation that echoed memories of better times. Tyrian was acutely aware that something profoundly wrong was unfolding, and the situation was deteriorating rapidly.

He recalled his father's words about the world attempting to "correct" the aberrations within its framework, but there was a threshold to such corrections. Now, it seemed they were rapidly approaching that limit.

Caught by a sudden intuition, Tyrian felt a familiar presence drawing near, prompting him to shift his focus from the distant horizon.

“Father,” he said, turning to face the tall figure shrouded in bandages and cloaked in black. “Why have you come?”

“The graveyard no longer requires my watch. With this avatar, I find myself with an abundance of time,” Duncan replied, joining Tyrian. His eyes traversed the night, following Tyrian’s previous gaze. “What are your thoughts?”

“Has the time come already?” Tyrian mused, his eyes searching the night with a complex emotion. “I thought we had more time—the ‘time’ you hinted at.”

After a brief silence, Duncan ominously stated, “…The Death God is dead.”

Tyrian paused, the weight of his father’s words momentarily eluding him.

“The world’s decline is hastening beyond our predictions. Its innate mechanism for self-correction is failing to ensure that those within the shelters remain in a ‘survival state’—that is, as living beings. Life, being a complex and high-maintenance condition, can no longer be fully sustained within the shelters,” Duncan explained somberly, his gaze fixated on some distant point, as if envisioning the world’s impending doom.

“This is why we’re witnessing the ‘resurrection of the dead’ across various city-states and the disturbing absence of newborns. Bartok has prematurely disrupted the world’s cycle of life and death.”

“His intervention was not meant to precipitate such a rapid degradation.”

“The shelters no longer need to sustain the living.”

“Moreover, the cessation of the death cycle allows for the majority to ‘endure’ in whatever form possible—be it as the undead. This grotesque

existence, however temporary, is a means to persist through the sanctuary's gradual collapse."

"This extended time is the legacy Bartok fought to leave for our world."

As Tyrian absorbed his father's revelations, a mix of shock and bewilderment rendered him speechless, his mind racing yet unable to articulate a response.

Duncan's voice, deep and gravelly, broke the silence once more, imparting a grave insight: "This might be the final instance where the Four Gods have managed to buy time for this sanctuary."

Finding his voice amidst the turmoil, Tyrian asked, "Why?"

Duncan explained the dire consequences of halting the death mechanism. "Its stop deals a critical blow to the sanctuary, marking the commencement of the final countdown. From this point, all semblance of order will rapidly begin to warp, and the world's innate ability to self-correct will fail completely. This breakdown is why the distortions and anomalies, once veiled from human awareness, will start to become glaringly apparent to more and more individuals."

As he turned to face Tyrian, his gaze was intense and penetrating.

Reeling from the onslaught of information and grappling with the implications of his father's sudden announcement, Tyrian found himself confronting memories and details he had unconsciously ignored or forgotten, surfacing like specters from a nightmare.

After a moment that seemed to stretch into an eternity, the fog of confusion in his mind began to clear, allowing his thoughts to coalesce and his rationality to resurface.

"So," he began, the words emerging tentatively, "ordinary people will soon…"

Duncan continued, “Having been influenced by me, you’ve been able to perceive many things prematurely. As the world’s distortions and anomalies grow more severe and the sanctuary’s self-correcting mechanisms fail entirely, more individuals will start to recognize the world’s aberrations—similar to your experience. It won’t be everyone; susceptibility will vary based on mental resilience, intuitive sensitivity, and a degree of… ‘luck.’”

“For those unable to perceive these changes, life will go on as usual in a world that’s becoming increasingly alien and frightening, without them sensing any shift in their reality.”

“However, for those who become aware… the situation will deteriorate significantly.”

“Tyrian, you must brace yourself—and the other city-states as well.”

“The ultimate, most tumultuous upheaval of the old world is on the horizon.”

…

Duncan and Agatha had been journeying along this mysterious “path” for what seemed like an eternity. As they moved forward, the strange, monochromatic grass that bordered their trail began to vanish. In its place, a landscape of endless, pale, and dark broken stones unfolded, with only the occasional withered plant breaking the monotony of the stone-strewn wilderness.

The ethereal twilight glow that once imbued the wilderness with a surreal quality gradually receded, giving way to the serene dominance of the night. The wilderness transformed before their eyes, adopting a more somber and desolate guise.

In a subdued tone, Agatha shared with Duncan that they were now entering a new segment of the “Path of No Return.” This stark and desolate region,

known as the “Death Wilderness,” lay deep within their journey. She described how, beyond the twilight—which symbolized the last vestige of life—a peaceful night awaited to usher in the realm of the deceased. The endless expanse of barren land, strewn with broken stones, signified the severance of the dead’s final ties to the mortal world. Crossing this threshold would lead them to the “Great Gate.”

However, Duncan realized that these once sacred symbols and rituals tied to the death mechanism had lost their significance.

Lifting his gaze towards the horizon, where the deepest part of the night sky stretched overhead, Duncan could discern a massive, indistinct shape looming at the heart of the wilderness.

Then, out of the corner of his eye, he noticed other presences for the first time.

Dressed in black robes, these figures were the “Gatekeepers,” still seemingly bathed in the twilight’s fading glow.

Silent and solemn, the Gatekeepers moved through the vast, desolate wilderness, all converging in the same direction. Their silent procession resembled a funeral march, each step a testament to the solemnity of their purpose as they navigated the boundless landscape of death.

Chapter 823: Burial

Beneath the cover of night, in a barren landscape strewn with gravel, numerous figures cloaked in black robes advanced silently in a single direction. Their path was lit by a mysterious twilight glow emanating from an unseen source, casting their long, night-like robes in a light that seemed both real and surreal. As they traversed the barren land, these solitary figures merged into streams of twilight, weaving through the darkness like rivers converging in the heart of a desolate wilderness of death, where they encircled a solemn gathering.

At the center of this wilderness stood a monumental gate, its triangular doors imposing yet silent. Duncan initially mistook it for a mere hill, but in an instant, he found himself standing before it, awestruck by its majestic rise from the ground, its triangular form sealed shut. Dark red veins sprawled across the door's surface like blood vessels, ensnaring it with the appearance of chains.

This gate, it seemed, was the barrier to the realm of death, now overseen by a deity seated on a throne before it. This deity towered over Duncan, his stature surpassing anyone Duncan could imagine, including Ta Ruijin. Even while seated, the deity's form was colossal, nearly as large as a house itself.

Adorned in a tattered black robe as dark as the night itself, wrapped with dark red thorns, the deity's presence was as imposing as it was mysterious. Under the long shadows cast by his robe, his face remained hidden, indistinct as if he were no more than a silhouette shaped by the fabric—echoing the teachings of the Death Church's holy scriptures:

“Death is a faceless shadow, omnipresently lurking within the shroud of darkness. When you gaze upon Him, He gazes back at you.”

Yet, this once formidable embodiment of death lay defeated, a grotesque, thorn-like short sword impaled through his chest, anchoring him to his dark throne. His hood was askew, suggesting that even in his final moments, he cast a longing glance towards the triangular gate, the very symbol of the cycle of life and death.

This tableau was akin to a self-inflicted demise, a murder where the victim was also the perpetrator.

Among the “Four Dead Gods,” this scene was unprecedented: at the threshold of death and decay, Bartok had enacted his own end, a second act of “self-destruction.”

Surrounding the gate, the twilight-clad figures stood as still as stone, resembling petrified tombstones in their motionlessness. Yet, amidst them, a path remained, as if intentionally left clear for those who would come to witness, stretching from the wilderness to the dark throne.

Leading the way was the towering gatekeeper, with Duncan and Agatha in tow. They made their way through the path flanked by the silent phantoms. The twilight glow from the figures bathed them in its light; Duncan remained unaffected, but Agatha, whose form was originally ethereal and translucent, began to solidify under the twilight’s touch, appearing momentarily to possess a physical body.

Having reached their journey’s climax, Duncan and his party halted before a majestic throne under the watchful eyes of the towering gatekeepers. The leader of these imposing figures offered a silent nod of acknowledgment before seamlessly rejoining his comrades along the sides of the throne room.

Duncan raised his gaze to the entity seated upon the throne, a presence more formidable than any they had encountered before, including Ta Ruijin. This was the entity known as the world's first and ultimate deceased, a being of immense power and mystery.

It became clear why the falsely "deceased" Sailor, brought forth by Agatha's magic, had failed to command the attention of these gatekeepers. They were guardians of the true end, the genuine deceased who commanded the throne.

Agatha, with a mixture of reverence and curiosity, stared intently at this dark-clad deity. It was a moment of profound significance for her. As a gatekeeper herself, imbued with the memories of those devout followers of the Death Church, she had never imagined she would stand in this sacred place. It was a realm believed unreachable by the countless devout throughout their lifetimes, let alone witness such a momentous event—the ceremonial end of the Grim Death God.

After a long and reflective silence, Agatha finally turned to Duncan, her voice tinged with complexity, "Captain, what do we do now?"

Before Duncan could formulate a response, another gatekeeper, who had been standing vigil by the throne, approached them. This spectral figure, towering and silent, handed Duncan an ancient and finely crafted hourglass before returning to his station. Duncan recognized the hourglass, identical to one he had seen in the final resting place of the Leviathan Queen, yet this one was devoid of sand.

Puzzled and intrigued, Duncan looked up to inquire about the hourglass, but was instead drawn into a mysterious understanding by a whispering breeze. Under Agatha's watchful eye, he activated the hourglass. A flicker of starlight-infused flame danced at his fingertips before merging into the

hourglass, reviving the once-recorded vitality in a spectacle of flowing flames and reversing sands.

In the blink of an eye, the environment around Duncan shifted dramatically. He found himself standing atop a small mound, bathed in a soft, ethereal light against the backdrop of an impenetrable night. Around him, wildflowers bloomed, their fragrance adding to the surrealism of the moment. The serene silence was punctuated by the sound of a shovel cutting through soil. Duncan turned to see a frail, elderly man diligently digging a shallow grave, his actions reflecting an eternity of labor in the soft, black earth.

This unexpected scene, unfolding under the guidance of the ancient hourglass, hinted at a deeper connection between life, death, and the realms beyond, inviting Duncan and Agatha into the mysteries that lay at the heart of existence itself.

As Duncan absorbed the somber beauty of the scene before him, he approached the old man who was tirelessly digging into the earth.

“I’m here… I apologize, I might have arrived a bit late,” Duncan offered tentatively, breaking the silence.

“It’s not late,” the old man responded without pausing his work, his voice steady and imbued with an ageless wisdom. “Death is never early nor late. It arrives precisely when it’s supposed to. Your timing is just right.”

He gestured towards a small mound of soil beside him, where, unnoticed until now, an additional shovel lay resting against the dark, piled earth. “Can you lend a hand?”

Wordlessly, Duncan stepped forward, picked up the shovel, and began to dig alongside the old man, their actions in silent harmony.

For a time, the only sounds were the rhythmic digging and the soft shifting of soil, a solemn melody on the mound.

After a while, the frail figure broke the silence, his voice carrying a hint of nostalgia. “The other three… It’s been ages since I last saw them. Since then, our only communication has been through the remnants left by the second guide. How are they?”

“They’re well,” Duncan replied, his voice calm and steady as he continued his task. “I’ve entered into a pact with them. We’ll reunite in the new world.”

A hint of warmth flickered in the old man’s demeanor. “That’s good to hear… A reunion is something to look forward to.”

After a brief pause, Duncan cast a curious glance at his companion. “Is this how you truly look?”

“No,” the old man admitted without ceasing his digging, his tone reflective. “I have never had a face, not since the beginning. But I thought… since I’m about to depart, I should at least leave behind a semblance of one.”

“You have no face?” Duncan echoed, intrigued and somewhat bewildered by the revelation.

“Yes, I am distinct from the others. I am ‘Death’ itself,” the old man confided softly, a profound solemnity in his voice.

Duncan remained silent, allowing the gravity of the statement to sink in, waiting for the old man to elaborate.

“Every end of a world is unique. Some linger for years, others much longer. And then there are those… civilizations that fight valiantly, employing every conceivable means to delay their inevitable demise, sometimes even for a century,” the old man mused, continuing his labor.

“In my world, the end came swiftly—so swiftly that there was no time for decay or defiance. Yet, it wasn’t so abrupt that people couldn’t perceive their doom. It was a pace that allowed everyone to witness the approach of their final moment.

“At that instant, every soul met their end. Death echoed through time and space, unsettling even the stars on the brink of extinction. In the last breath of my world, ‘Death’ became the brightest, most universal, the sole entity to emerge in the entirety of the cosmos.

“And in that fleeting second, everything beautiful and ugly, every fear and act of bravery, every resilience and fragility inherent in human nature and thought, was encapsulated.

“From that culmination of death, I came into being. Upon opening my eyes for the first time, I watched everything collapse before me. By the second blink, all that remained of the world I had glimpsed only once was scorched, chaotic ashes.”

With a measured push, the old man drove his shovel into the earth, skillfully excavating another portion of soil from the grave before him, and flung it aside.

“I’ve been at this task for ages, ever since the haven was conceived. I’ve toiled away at digging this pit, a labor that seemed almost endless – after all, vanquishing death itself is no minor feat. Yet, here you are, aiding me, Fire Usurper.”

His gaze then turned introspective, as if pondering an uncharted future. “Don’t you yearn to witness the new world? There might still be a path open to us…”

“No, but thank you for the offer,” the old man responded with a gentle shake of his head, scooping and discarding another handful of earth. He

then paused to meet Duncan's gaze with a serene clarity. "I'm unlike others you may know; this much you might have surmised. I am not a relic of the old world, but rather a creation of the Great Annihilation, forged from those fiery ashes. Thus, the duty to dictate this world's decay, to establish its cycle of life and death, fell upon me alone – the haven necessitated such a 'recycling system.' But in the forthcoming world, the decay of things should not be under the dominion of a similar 'deity.' Even the suggestion of such a possibility is flawed. Let all that emerged from the Great Annihilation remain with it."

A reflective silence enveloped Duncan as he cast another shovelful of soil into the grave.

"Do you harbor any regrets?"

"No," the old man replied with a serene smile, "I've accomplished all that was required of me. Now, to relish an eternal, undisturbed rest is the finest payment for 'Death'. But for you, I offer a piece of counsel."

Duncan ceased his movements, attentive.

"Refrain from treating sacrifice lightly. Though it may seem odd coming from me," the old man continued, locking eyes with Duncan, "I detect on you the scent of martyrdom…a scent all too familiar to me, yet it ought not to cling to you."

Duncan stood in silence, absorbing the moment.

When he looked again, the frail old man and the second shovel were no longer beside him. It was just Duncan standing there, alone.

The deity of death had taken his rest in the grave, his form nearly enveloped by the earth. He closed his eyes in peace, as if he had been resting there since time immemorial.

After a moment steeped in silence, Duncan bent forward once more, continuing his solemn duty of covering the grave with soil, carrying out the last rites for a being as ancient and as pivotal as the concept of death itself.

Chapter 824: After the Death Gods Rest

Dark, fertile soil cascaded down, covering the modest grave beneath it like the encroaching night sky at the culmination of existence, concealing an eternal demise. The deity birthed from the silence that enveloped all things now lay in rest, in the precise moment when the world edged towards its conclusion, transforming into a humble mound atop a hill.

A chaotic breeze swept through the darkness, tenderly caressing the small earthen mound. Nameless wildflowers and grasses adorning the mound danced in the wind, producing a soft, whispering sound. Standing amidst the gusts, Duncan clutched his shovel, his gaze fixated on the newly formed mound of earth in front of him.

He then surveyed the surroundings – the deity of death hadn’t arranged for a headstone for itself, and there were no materials in the vicinity that could be fashioned into one.

With a decisive action, Duncan thrust the shovel, previously used for digging, into the ground in front of the mound, stabilizing it with soil at its base to serve as an improvised marker.

Having done this, he inhaled deeply, laying his hand upon the shovel’s handle one final time.

A subtle greenish glow, mingled with the faint light of distant stars, emanated from his fingers, gradually enveloping the makeshift “headstone” of the deity of death before fading away.

“May you rest in peace, Bartok, until we meet again,” Duncan murmured softly, his form gradually dissolving into the wind.

The turbulent wind transformed into a brief cry, as light and shadow emerged from the darkness and swiftly reassembled. After experiencing a moment of weightlessness and a shift in perception, Duncan felt the solidity of the ground return beneath his feet, and the landscape around him quickly came into focus.

The majestic Gate of Death still stood, unyielding, in the midst of the devastated stony wilderness. Before the triangular gateway, the imposing figure seated upon the dark throne silently crumbled away, akin to a fragmenting dream dispelling at dawn. The unseen presence cloaked in a black robe dispersed with the wind, and the robe itself descended like the night, decaying and eroding into nothingness.

Among the scattering black fragments and dust, only a delicate greenish light, paired with dim starlight, flickered in the breeze.

Duncan bowed his head, noticing the edge of the hourglass in his grasp shimmering faintly, with vague whispers seemingly resonating beside him. Realizing something profound, he advanced and placed the ancient yet finely crafted hourglass beside the throne, once occupied by the deity of death.

Retreating, he saw Agatha standing silently, her gaze fixed on the now vacant throne. After an indeterminate span of time, the “Gatekeeper,” born of illusions, slowly turned her head, her eyes reflecting a mixture of complex emotions: “…Has He found peace?”

“Yes, I accompanied Him on His final journey,” Duncan responded gently, then added, “The hourglass harbors a fragment of His essence. I’ve positioned it next to the throne, ensuring that the mortal realm’s Death

Church can still momentarily access some ‘blessings’… they will continue to require them.”

Agatha’s response was a slow, deliberate nod. She seemed as if she were on the cusp of articulating a cascade of thoughts and emotions, yet words eluded her. In place of speech, her inner turmoil found expression in a soft sigh so faint it barely stirred the air.

“The time to return is upon us,” Duncan intoned, a gravity in his voice hinting at the urgency of their situation. “The final countdown has begun. We must make haste back to the node of the Leviathan Queen without delay.”

Acknowledging Duncan’s directive with a soft hum, Agatha cast her gaze back the way they had come, only to behold a desolate expanse of broken stones stretching into the horizon, devoid of any discernible features to mark their path.

The surrounding darkness seemed to claim this silent domain entirely, a realm where paths once trodden by the dead offered no passage for return.

Yet, in that moment of despair, a startling change occurred. The enigmatic “Gatekeepers” encircling the throne of the Death God began to stir. These silent, monolithic spectres initiated a solemn procession, lifting their hands one by one. They pointed into the darkness, from which a twilight-like illumination began to emerge, weaving through the air in the direction they indicated. This light seemed to gather and flow unseen, paving a path through the wasteland.

Guided by the silent decree of these towering phantasms, a pathway materialized amidst the desolation, bathed in a soft, twilight glow. Along its borders, unnamed wildflowers burst into bloom, their petals swaying gently in the breeze.

For the first time in this dominion of death, as the machinations of mortality ceased and the Death God lay in rest, a way back to the realm of the living was revealed.

Witnessing this miraculous emergence, Agatha could only stare in wonder. Her eyes instinctively sought out the Gatekeeper who had initially led them, finding him in a silent farewell, his gesture a solemn directive: Leave, and never again linger in the domain of death.

Heeding this silent counsel, she, alongside Duncan, embarked upon the newly formed path, leaving the desolate wasteland behind them.

Their journey back was marked by solitude, with only the occasional gust of wind for company. The wasteland gradually receded from view, giving way to the familiar sight of black and white, unnamed wild grasses swaying in the wilderness. As they pressed on, the towering silhouettes of the Vanished and the Bright Star loomed in the distance. Approaching these landmarks, Duncan and Agatha found themselves back at their point of departure.

The paper-folded boat awaited them, with Lucretia standing at its bow, her expression a mix of bewilderment and surprise. Upon noticing Duncan, her eyebrows arched in astonishment before she leaped down to greet them.

“Have you been here the entire time?” Duncan inquired, taken aback by the sight of the “Sea Witch” who seemed to have scarcely moved, “Our absence was extended…”

“You left but a few minutes ago,” Lucretia replied, her astonishment mirroring Duncan’s. “As soon as you and Agatha disappeared behind a curtain of twilight-hued light, you’ve returned seemingly out of nowhere. I feared you might have been thrust into an unforeseen predicament.”

“A few minutes?” Duncan’s brow furrowed at this revelation, yet he quickly shelved his bewilderment. Given the series of extraordinary events they had encountered, such anomalies had become almost routine.

“Our task is complete,” he declared with finality, “We shall depart right away.”

Lucretia’s gaze shifted between Duncan and Agatha, sensing that the duo had traversed an epic saga within what, to her, had seemed a mere handful of minutes. Yet, she refrained from probing further, instead offering a subtle nod in agreement, “…Alright.”

…

As the pale flames within the brazier died out, the soft, indistinct whispers that had been echoing in her mind also faded away. Agatha, who had been kneeling in a meditative stance within the sanctuary of the prayer room, lifted her head, drawn by a subtle intuition, and turned her attention towards the mirror adjacent to her.

Blindfolded, she was deprived of conventional sight, yet this limitation bestowed upon her a heightened spiritual clarity. This unique perception unveiled the essence of other dimensions, realms beyond the grasp of the average eye.

Reflected in the mirror, she perceived a vision fleeting yet profound—a solitary grave set against a desolate, dark landscape, with the light of twilight dwindling on the horizon.

This ephemeral glimpse into another reality was momentary, yet its message was clear and resonant to Agatha, who held the dual roles of a youthful Gatekeeper and an Archbishop. She comprehended the grave implications of what this scene represented.

Silently, she continued to kneel before the sacred statue, and after a brief moment of contemplation, bowed her head once more, resuming her silent prayers. Her lips moved without sound, offering benedictions for those who had passed from this world to the next.

Her prayer, succinct yet poignant, was recited thrice. Rising gracefully from her kneeling posture, Agatha approached a nearby shelf. From a wooden box, she selected a dried flower, its petals pale and delicate, and placed it next to the candlestick that stood before the image of sanctity.

Outside, the ambient sounds of the city's restlessness permeated the walls of the church, a distant cacophony of life's unceasing tumult.

Footsteps, hurried and purposeful, approached from the corridor. Soon, a voice belonging to a member of the clergy echoed just outside the sanctuary: "Archbishop, are you present?"

"Enter," Agatha's voice carried a calm authority.

The prayer room's door swung open, revealing a middle-aged clergyman. His short, dark hair and the bandages covering half of his face gave him a distinct appearance. His attention was immediately captured by the sight of the white flower positioned solemnly before the holy figure.

A frown creased his brow as he observed the flower, a sense of significance nagging at the edge of his consciousness. There was a question to be asked, a meaning to be deciphered, yet it eluded him, leaving his gaze clouded with confusion and a lack of understanding.

Agatha, sensing his perplexity, positioned herself so that she stood between him and the symbolic white flower.

"What concerns you?" she inquired, her voice embodying both curiosity and command.

The clergyman’s expression of confusion briefly intensified before clarity returned to him. He promptly relayed his message: “Archbishop, a new group has arrived at the cathedral seeking shelter and guidance. There are about a dozen of them. Following your directives, I’ve dispatched Mark along with Sister Natasha to welcome them.”

“Understood,” Agatha acknowledged with a nod, her demeanor composed. She then inquired further, a casual tone bellying the depth of her concern, “What can you tell me about these newcomers? From whence have they come?”

“They’re quite distressed, caught in a whirlwind of fear and confusion, struggling to articulate the nature of their distress,” he began. “The one among them who appears to be in the best shape shared that he experienced a sudden awakening earlier today. To his alarm, he found that many aspects of his surroundings felt profoundly wrong. Familiar faces of relatives and friends now seemed foreign and, disturbingly, frightening. Overwhelmed by fear, he sought refuge at a local chapel, where he encountered others in similar straits.”

“The resident priest at the chapel took immediate action, offering solace and blessings to calm their spirits, before assigning two guardians to safely lead them through the city to our doorstep.”

“Their origins are diverse, with the majority hailing from neighborhoods around the southern port and a few from the vicinity of the cemetery district. They seem to have no prior connections, sharing neither acquaintances nor common traits in their backgrounds…”

Agatha absorbed the clergyman’s account with a serene demeanor, her response a silent nod of acknowledgment. “The municipal authorities will be making arrangements later on. There’s provisional accommodation prepared at the mountain’s base.”

“Understood,” the clergyman said, then paused, his gaze resting on Agatha with a mix of hesitance and concern. He seemed to search the interim Archbishop’s face for clues, torn over voicing his next thought. “Archbishop, can you shed any light on what’s unfolding? These episodes have been escalating in frequency, affecting even the church…”

“John,” Agatha interjected, her tone preempting further inquiry, “Do you recall the guidance I offered our congregation the day before yesterday?”

A shift crossed the clergyman’s features as he nodded in recognition.

Agatha continued, her voice imbued with a tranquil yet firm resolve. “I cannot provide you with the clarity you seek at this moment, for the simple reason that the explanations would elude you—much like those voices remain unheard by you. However, should you find yourself abruptly ‘awakening,’ do not succumb to fear. Proceed directly to the inner sanctum. There, you will find someone ready to guide and assist you through whatever comes next.”

Chapter 825: Circular Convergence

Priest John departed with a complex yet determined look on his face. He asked no questions before leaving, nor did Agatha offer any further explanation.

Now, Agatha found herself alone again in the prayer room, where the bright lights fought valiantly against the encroaching darkness from outside, which seemed almost to have a physical presence. The candlesticks in front of the sacred statue flickered weakly with a few lingering flames while wisps of smoke continued to rise from the recently extinguished fire in the basin. In a nearby floor mirror, Agatha's reflection appeared fragmented and disjointed.

Turning towards the revered image of Bartok, she raised her head. Although her eyes were covered by a black cloth, she gazed intently at the figure enshrouded in the night. To her, the statue, which remained unchanged to any observer, now seemed to be filled with cracks, resembling a pile of debris miraculously held together by some unseen force.

The atmosphere within the cathedral felt increasingly filled with the presence of death. It was as though the very foundation of this world was slowly decaying and dying. Now, it seemed nearly everyone was transitioning from the living to the state of the dead. Individuals who had died unwittingly were active throughout the city-state, including within the church itself. John had passed away, succumbing during midday prayers the

previous day; Sister Lora had died in a light sleep. Yet, they continued their duties within the cathedral as if nothing had changed.

Abruptly, a flicker of uncertain flame appeared in the mirror beside her, turning it pitch black before a figure emerged clearly within it.

As Agatha turned, she saw not Captain Duncan in the reflection but Tyrian.

Tyrian spoke first, “My father crafted this path to forge connections among those ‘blessed’ by his fire. Miss Agatha, how are things with you?”

“The number of deceased within the cathedral is on the rise,” Agatha replied softly, a hint of sorrow in her voice. “Many have transitioned from living to dead under surprisingly ordinary circumstances. It seems unstoppable, beyond the reach of any remedy or safeguard.”

“The same situation is unfolding elsewhere in the city-state,” Tyrian responded gravely, “and indeed, in other city-states across the world.”

Agatha nodded in acknowledgment, pausing to consider before she added, “But the presence of the moving dead is not our greatest concern. The true problem lies in the increasing number of people who are ‘awakening.’”

“Yes,” Tyrian acknowledged with a grave tone, “As my father had forewarned, the mechanism designed to ‘correct’ the world is breaking down. The god of death’s last intervention delayed the complete collapse of our sanctuary but, in the process, damaged its ‘correction’ mechanism. Now, this protective barrier, which was supposed to safeguard the minds of ordinary individuals, is deteriorating, and it’s happening more rapidly than we anticipated.”

“Even so, Governor Tyrian, I urge you not to worry excessively. Whether it be the clergy within our church or the guardians and law enforcement personnel outside, many have spent their entire lives training to face such unprecedented calamities, even those that directly impact them.”

“It’s likely that no one foresaw a reality where gods would forever slumber, where even our world would face demise, or that our current predicament would be as grave as it is. Nevertheless, we’ve prepared for ‘everything.’ No matter the circumstance, our primary commitment is to our duties without conditions.

“A few days back, I briefed our team of priests. I informed them about an unfolding disaster, invisible to them as of yet, advised them on safeguarding those ‘awakening,’ and provided guidance for dealing with their own potential ‘awakening.’

“Some of them now share our understanding of the situation, while others have yet to comprehend the full significance of these directives – but this has not hindered their adherence to them.

“I trust that the external law enforcement will act similarly.

“Among any group, there will undoubtedly be individuals who falter, who are overwhelmed by fear or mental strain, failing to meet their responsibilities. Yet, importantly, those who steadfastly fulfil their roles are not few, Governor Tyrian. Regardless of when or how the world’s end arrives, we are ready for it.”

Upon hearing Agatha’s determined words, Tyrian allowed himself a moment of reflection before his expression softened, and he nodded in agreement: “I plan to enlarge the ‘quarantine zone’ and set up a network of shelters around the cemetery area – utilizing the cemetery’s inherent defenses for the gradual relocation and safeguarding of our populace. This effort will necessitate the church’s collaboration.”

“This will be a challenging and extensive endeavor,” Agatha remarked. “With the ‘living’ and ‘dead’ intermingling, and people awakening unpredictably from amongst them, we lack the means to fully discern this transformation. We can’t relocate all awakened individuals to shelters, nor

can we view the others as adversaries, even if they roam aimlessly, akin to zombies.”

“I understand, but we must strive to do our utmost,” Tyrian replied with steady composure, “It’s preferable to descending into utter, uncontrollable chaos – should the worst occur, at least we’ll have established sufficient shelters to safeguard a segment of our community.”

“…I understand. The church will fully support City Hall’s initiatives as they await your directives.”

…

Before the ark-like colossal ship, reminiscent of a small city-state, stood a vast array of hydraulic machinery at its prow, forming a formidable mechanical barrier. Countless heavy metal battering rams, arranged in precise order along this “mechanical wall,” were methodically hoisted along their tracks before crashing down forcefully. These metallic behemoths acted like a multitude of sharp teeth, relentlessly crushing the thick ice ahead. Amidst the continuous roar of machinery and the thunderous sound of ice shattering, the church ark persisted in its slow advance through the icy maritime expanse.

This ice-breaking mechanism carved a lengthy path through the ice layer, leaving behind a trail that pointed back towards civilization. Ahead, nothing but solid ice and darkness stretched into the distance, with the dense fog that marked the “border” churning and swelling at the edge of visibility, growing more ominous and formidable, yet seemingly always just out of reach.

Frem stood atop the church ark, his gaze fixed on the endless icy plains stretching out before him, flanked by two fire basins ablaze with flames as cold as ice. These flames crackled with low, indistinct murmurs as if hiding secrets within their glow.

He felt the “focus” that had been revealed to him in the latest revelation by the flame tower, Ta Ruijin, was near. This unique point held the potential to maintain the “legacy” in its pure form during the transition from the old world to the new.

Frem was aware that the “Captain” was orchestrating a monumental plan akin to the creation of a world. He understood that success would herald the arrival of a “new world” – a concept beyond his ability to visualize. Yet, he was certain it would be vastly superior to the twisted, dark, and crisis-laden expanse of the Boundless Sea that currently enveloped them.

This new realm promised a place for everyone, a fact Frem gleaned from the sporadic messages that had returned from the edge of the known world.

However, this rebirth necessitated destruction; everything from the old world would be eradicated in this transformative process. The “Captain” might possess the means to “rebirth” individuals in this new world, but what of the creations left behind?

What would become of the poems, the melodies, the remarkable works of art, the precious scrolls and tablets chronicling the Dark Ages, the Old City-State Era, the New City-State Era, and the essence of a once-thriving civilization? Was there a way to safeguard these artifacts?

Even if preservation were possible, these remnants of the past could pose a significant challenge during the process of world creation, potentially becoming a monumental burden.

This deep-rooted concern propelled the Flame Bearers on their arduous journey northward, and now, after enduring countless hardships, they were on the cusp of reaching their goal.

Their mission was to bestow a “legacy” upon the inhabitants of the new world, safeguarded within this eternally frozen ice field.

It was within reach, just beyond them.

Yet, an unexpected, shrill noise erupted in the distance, swiftly followed by a cacophony of explosions and the grinding sound of metal on metal. The ark beneath their feet shuddered violently, emitting a deep groan as if some internal mechanism had ceased operation.

A sense of dread washed over Frem in an instant.

Shortly thereafter, a woman priestess, clad in a dark robe and her face obscured by a veil, rushed to Frem's side.

"Your Holiness, the main power conduit of the ice-breaking device has suffered a rupture!"

…

Meanwhile, the Vanished and Bright Star traversed a monochromatic grey-white expanse. At the end of this prolonged "transition channel," a subtle infusion of color was beginning to emerge.

Duncan, stationed at the bow of the Vanished, gazed silently towards the slowly materializing seascape ahead. He detected approaching footsteps, accompanied by a sense of "warmth" that had become a rarity in this world.

Turning, Duncan observed Nina behind him, enveloped in a gentle radiance, the sunlight cascading around her, seemingly dispelling the pervasive chill left by the world's demise.

"…Have you discovered a new application for 'sunlight'?" Duncan queried, his eyebrows arched in amusement, a smile gracing his face before he grew contemplative, "Your control has become increasingly refined – initially, even attempting to boil water with a flame would result in singed hair."

Nina responded with a slight squint, "Yes, and it would occasionally singe those shadowy passersby from the darkness and various demons."

“…I’m inclined to believe their presence wasn’t merely coincidental.”

“It’s of no consequence.”

A momentary silence ensued between them.

Then, in a soft tone, Nina broke the silence, “…We’re almost there.”

“Yes,” Duncan replied gently, poised to articulate further thoughts, but before he could, the indistinct hues at the periphery of his vision burst forth into a serene expanse of sea and islands dotting the horizon.

“Space jump… concluded.”

Chapter 826: The Final Assembly

The abrupt end of the spatial jump transition signaled the reappearance of the Vanished and Bright Star, emerging from the nondescript, gray-white void of space. Their arrival was accompanied by a gentle shudder and vibration, akin to vessels smoothly gliding into the peaceful, mirror-like surface of a serene sea.

After a prolonged expedition to the farthest reaches of the known world, the two spacecraft had returned to their point of origin—the initial node they had discovered and the final resting place of the legendary Leviathan Queen.

Upon their return, the environment seemed unchanged from their departure. The Boundless Sea remained eerily still, and the scattered shadowy islands were cloaked in persistent mist. The largest island was just barely discernible through the dense fog, its outlines faintly appearing like an apparition from a dream.

The atmosphere was noticeably quieter than before—the typical subtle disturbances on the water's surface were absent, and the continuous, low whispers of the fog had fallen silent. Even the breeze sweeping across the deck carried a sound that was muted and distant.

The crew gathered at the ship's bow railing, their eyes fixed on the distant islands and the familiar seascape they had not seen in a long time. After a moment of reflective silence, Nina broke the quiet, her voice laden with wonder and nostalgia: "Without realizing it, we've been navigating the edges of the world for such a long time…"

Morris, standing next to her, responded in a subdued tone, “Yes, so long that I almost forgot this journey had an end.” He adjusted the focus of his ruby-colored glasses and added, “I believe I’ll carry the memories of everything we witnessed on this journey forever.”

Turning to Morris, Vanna commented, “This will undoubtedly lead to a series of remarkable discoveries and scholarly articles.”

Morris paused briefly before replying, “No one writes or reads scholarly papers anymore—the world has begun to decline, and no new discoveries will rekindle those fading embers.”

Vanna shook her head, her voice infused with hope: “Then we’ll leave that to a distant future—one where the spark of curiosity is reignited, and people seek knowledge and wisdom once again.”

Shirley, leaning against the railing, looked out at the horizon and murmured to herself, “Ah, yet here we are, back again.”

Behind the group, Duncan felt the collective gaze of his crew turn towards him, awaiting his command.

He was prepared for this moment, and as it arrived, he took a deep breath and commanded calmly, “We will dock by the island with the temple, and then everyone will transfer to the Bright Star for departure. We’ll keep in touch using the flame.”

Lucretia appeared about to speak but then opted for silence, closing her mouth.

“But before we do that,” Duncan continued, “let’s gather in the dining hall one last time.”

Footsteps resonated across the deck as Alice, the doll who had just finished her tasks at the helm, approached the captain and the rest of the crew.

“Alice, it’s time to showcase your culinary skills,” Duncan called out with a smile as he saw the doll-like figure approach, “We’re about to enjoy a meal.”

Alice hesitated momentarily at his words, but then her expression transformed into a bright, cheerful smile, and she nodded eagerly, “Ah! Okay!”

Lucretia quickly interjected, “I’ll fetch Luni and Nilu. They can help in the kitchen—and I’ll also bring the fine wine from the Bright Star.”

“I’ll help too!” Nina exclaimed, her expression radiating warmth like sunlight, “With my help, the cooking will be finished in no time!”

Alice seemed slightly overwhelmed by the enthusiastic offers to assist, gesturing dismissively with her hands, “Ah, there’s no need for so many helpers, I can manage on my own…”

However, after a moment of consideration, she sighed resignedly, “Well, if you really want to help, then come along…”

As the Vanished continued its journey through the mist-enshrouded islands towards the dark island with the grand temple, a unique gathering quickly took shape in the ship’s dining hall.

The long table, central to many previous gatherings and welcoming to all aboard, was once again positioned in the heart of the dining hall. Nina ignited the lanterns on the surrounding pillars with flames as bright as the sun, while Luni and Alice prepared a lavish spread of food and fine wine on the table. For a brief moment, the warmth and light they generated seemed to dispel the eternal night of the Boundless Sea and the pervasive chill of the outside.

Duncan took his place at the center of the table, flanked by Nina on his left and Alice on his right. Nearby sat Morris, Shirley, Dog, Sailor, Luni, Nilu,

as well as Ai the dove and Agatha in her phantom form, who did not require food.

At both ends of the table, three chairs remained conspicuously vacant—Duncan had set them aside but remained silent about whom they were intended for.

As everyone settled in, Nilu, a diminutive doll, climbed onto the table. She grasped a large bottle of wine, dashing back and forth, pouring the dark-red liquid that shimmered like blood in the sunlight into each glass from the Bright Star's private stock.

Duncan raised his glass, but a sudden recollection caused him to pause and scan the room, his expression marked by complexity.

After a brief moment, his face relaxed slightly, and he quietly shifted his chair to the opposite side of the table.

Alice promptly adjusted her chair to maintain her position to Duncan's right as he repositioned himself at the table. Ai, the dove, flapped its wings and followed suit, settling near Duncan. The others, seated across from him, watched with puzzled expressions as they tried to decipher the captain's sudden change.

"The position I was in just now wasn't auspicious," Duncan admitted with a half-smile, struggling to articulate the strange thought that had prompted his movement. He gestured dismissively to those across the table, "Don't bother moving; stay where you are—it's luckier this way."

The crew on the other side listened, none quite understanding the captain's reasoning. Morris suspected it was some arcane joke known only to captains, a bit of gallows humor from subspace. Meanwhile, Nina, after a brief pause, burst into laughter.

"What are you laughing at?" Duncan asked, his gaze sharp.

“Nothing, just felt a sudden relief,” Nina replied with a mischievous grin from across the table, “The way you seriously mentioned ‘not auspicious’ just then was more comforting than anything else you’ve ever said.”

Duncan’s eyes flickered with realization at Nina’s tease, and he cleared his throat, “Ahumph, as I’ve mentioned, this is our last gathering on the ship for this journey. After this, we’ll dock at the Leviathan Queen’s resting place and then part ways, understood?”

“Yes, understood, Uncle Duncan,” Nina responded, her eyes twinkling with a mix of respect and jest. She lifted her glass, her face alight with expectation, “Then, may I have some fermented grape juice or wheat fruit juice today?”

It had been a while since Duncan had heard such a request from Nina. A smile crossed his face as he nodded, “Today you can, Shirley, you too—no need to sneak drinks today.”

Shirley, who was swirling her glass idly, looked up startled by Duncan’s comment, instinctively straightening up, “I haven’t been sneaking drinks!”

Duncan offered a knowing half-smile, “Didn’t you notice when you were sneaking drinks on the ship that the bottles, glasses, and the liquor were all sorts of ‘mirrors’?”

Caught off guard, Shirley was at a loss for words.

Duncan shook his head, still smiling, and raised his glass, “To this journey.”

Thus, everyone with hands lifted their glasses, those capable of drinking did so, and those who could not, spilled their wine onto the floor of the Vanished in a symbolic toast.

Even Ai, the dove, participated earnestly, dipping its beak into the glass, its demeanor more solemn than ever.

Alice stood up and began serving the meal to everyone at the long table. She lifted the lid of the pot that sat in the center, revealing a rich fish soup that was customary for everyone to enjoy. Beside the pot, there was a large plate of golden-brown sweet pancakes, a favorite treat from Pland that the captain adored.

Once Alice had distributed the initial servings, Nilu, the tiny doll only as tall as an adult's arm, scampered back onto the table. She deftly carried soup bowls and plates of pancakes to everyone, her cheerful demeanor showing no sign of comprehending the significance of "this journey," yet she appeared very joyful.

"I didn't expect such a little one like her to be capable of working so well," Shirley commented, her tone filled with wonder as she watched Nilu bustling back and forth. "I remember when I first saw her, she wouldn't move, just lying in a wooden box. She was said to be Luni's sister from long ago, left lying in a doll shop for a hundred years…"

"Nilu's awakening turned out to be a great success, and the process of endowing her with reason and humanity went incredibly smoothly," Lucretia interjected casually, "It might be due to the unique conditions at the frontier and Luni's influence… this little one seemed predisposed to 'activate' from the start."

Nilu approached Lucretia, cheerfully placing down the soup bowl and opening her arms wide, emitting a tiny, delicate sound: "Affinity!"

Watching this scene with a gentle smile, Duncan suddenly posed a question, "Have you thought about the new world?"

Nina paused, her expression showing a moment of confusion: "The new world… what about it?"

“In the new world, what do you want? Or rather…” Duncan paused thoughtfully, his gaze sweeping seriously across everyone at the long table, “What do you imagine the new world to be like?”

Chapter 827: Farewell

At the expansive dining table, the crew members exchanged hesitant glances, each taken aback by the captain's unexpected question. The room fell silent as they puzzled over the underlying meaning of his inquiry.

After a moment of thoughtful silence, Nina had a sudden realization. She considered her response carefully before speaking in a soft voice, "Perhaps… a safer place to live? It's hard to imagine… I think the best place would be Pland before the sun became problematic. Ideally, it would be more spacious. Living in a city-state feels confining, a feeling that's especially noticeable after experiencing the vast openness of the sea. The world is so vast, yet finding enough space to simply stand feels remarkably limited…"

Duncan, giving her a reassuring smile, agreed, "Indeed, there will certainly be a broader, safer habitable area in the future," then he turned to Shirley, who was seated next to Nina. "And what about you, Shirley? What are your hopes for this new world?"

Shirley, her mouth half-full of a biscuit, replied somewhat indistinctly, "I haven't thought much about it—just essentials like enough food and clothing. It would be wonderful if utilities like water and electricity were more affordable."

Duncan gently corrected her, "That's more a wish for a better society, not necessarily the world itself. Perhaps think a bit bigger?"

After a thoughtful pause and another bite of her biscuit, Shirley's expression became contemplative. Finally, she said, "Well… my hopes are similar to Nina's—a safer, bigger place. You're right; everything else really depends on the people… Oh, Dog, he would love a large house, or even just a vast, empty lot where Dog can roam freely without being disturbed…"

Duncan nodded, smiling, and shifted his attention to Morris, who was nearby.

"As a scholar, I realize that no society composed of people is ever perfect, even if the environment is safer. People themselves can introduce new challenges. That's part of why societies evolve and progress," Morris explained with a shrug. "So rather than envisioning a 'perfect' new world, I'd prefer more opportunities for research and more unexplored phenomena to study. More unprecedented events, more wondrous places, more remote destinations worth exploring. I dream that we can delve deeply into the principles of things without our research being obstructed by various 'dark barriers' and 'contradictions'. I hope for a world where knowledge isn't dangerous, where scholars don't fear for their lives each time they open a book. I wish for humanity to advance beyond the unspeakable fears that keep us tied to our birthplaces."

Morris let out a soft sigh, a spontaneous smile spreading across his face, "If that were possible, it would indeed be a marvelous place…"

"I just wish to regain my sense of taste and have a normal sleep cycle," interjected Sailor, who had been quiet until now, muttering, "I haven't had a good night's sleep in centuries."

Vanna was the next to speak, her expression wistful and filled with longing. "My hope," she said, her voice tinged with emotion, "is to witness what 'continents' are really like. I imagine vast and fertile stretches, numerous cities and 'nations' flourishing in the world, with people traveling easily

between these cities. I’m curious about what such a scene would truly look like.”

Shirley, surprised by the idea, responded with wide eyes, “Is that even possible? A land as big as the ocean?”

With a knowing half-smile, Vanna replied, “Didn’t you just express a desire for a ‘more spacious’ place? Continents are far more expansive than city-states.”

Shirley, slightly embarrassed, responded by pursing her lips, “I was just thinking out loud… I can’t really picture it either…”

Agatha, her ethereal form gliding past the dining table, chimed in with a magical tone, “Yes, it’s difficult to imagine things we’ve never experienced. As for the new world—I have almost no specific desires for it. It should be a benevolent place, and my only wish is to keep traveling with the Vanished. Despite being the newest member aboard this ship, I’ve already encountered landscapes beyond anything I ever imagined. It’s a pity our journey is coming to an end…”

Shirley’s expression suddenly brightened, “Then I hope to remain with the Vanished! There’s nothing more enjoyable than adventuring with this ship.”

Nina laughed, swaying in her chair, “I agree, it would be ideal if we could return to the Vanished.”

Their eyes briefly met Duncan’s, but quickly shifted away to the ‘Sea Witch’ Lucretia, who had remained silent throughout the conversation. Observing their gazes, Lucretia snapped out of her reverie.

“Will the Bright Star and my crew have a place in the new world?” she asked curiously. “This includes Luni, Nilu, and Rabbi, as well as the metallic man-servants and wooden maid-servants I’ve created… Are such beings permitted in the new world?”

Duncan had been quietly absorbing the various dreams and visions of his crew, sketching out the future world in his mind. Lucretia's question drew him back to the present. After a moment of thoughtful consideration, he assured her, "They will have a place—all beings will find a home."

Simultaneously, Shirley and Nina eagerly asked, "Will the Vanished also be there?"

Duncan hesitated slightly before affirming, "The Vanished will be there," he nodded decisively, "in some form or another. I will ensure that everything and everyone reaches the new world in the most suitable manner. Then, you can still come back to the Vanished, and we will explore even further."

Lucretia's expression gradually transformed into one of contentment, her smile broadening: "Then this time, please bring my brother—even from across the Boundless Sea and through various barriers, I can almost sense his resentment."

Duncan remained silent for a few moments, then responded with a deep nod, "Okay."

Lucretia let out a relieved sigh, stood up, and lifted her wine glass.

"Then, let us toast to the new world," she proposed, her smile reflecting a blend of hope and anticipation.

Agatha also rose, her glass held high: "To the new world!"

Others joined in with their own enthusiastic cheers:

"To the captain!"

"To the Vanished!"

"To the future!"

"…Uh, I don't know what to say, damn it, cheers!"

The gathering lifted their glasses in unison. Nina, having consumed a considerable amount of beer and wine, grinned broadly, her cheeks flushed: “Shirley, give some to Ai; she doesn’t have hands… How does this dove manage to drink so much? It’s all gone?”

She then glanced around the table: “Let’s include Luni in the toast… And Nilu, too. Can Nilu even drink?”

The small doll eagerly raised a glass nearly as large as herself and exclaimed, “Yes!”

As she spoke, she embraced the glass and gulped down its contents in one swift motion. Red wine dribbled from the joints of her neck, staining her exquisite doll dress.

Luni reacted with surprise and immediately started apologizing, hastily trying to dab at the wine stains on Nilu with a handkerchief.

Nina leaned forward, offering to help: “Hey, that won’t dry quickly; let me dry her off. Don’t let her move…”

Shirley quickly intervened, grabbing Nina by the collar to stop her: “No! You’ll just scorch it again! Remember what happened to your white dress with the blue trim?”

Amidst the commotion, Dog remained unperturbed, his two paws holding his glass while the liquid poured into his bony neck. The liquor fizzed inside his chest cavity and evaporated almost immediately as he shook his massive skeletal head, murmuring, “This wine has no taste… In the new world, I hope I can taste things normally…”

As he spoke, he sensed an attentive gaze and looked up to find the captain watching the scene with an amused smile: “It’s possible.”

Observing the unfolding chaos, Lucretia shook her head with a mixture of amusement and resignation, “If I had known it would end in chaos, I would

have brought Rabbi. That rabbit thrives on chaos, creating mischief even when it's unnecessary…"

"Yeah, Rabbi would have been perfect for this," Luni agreed, continuing to handle the thoroughly drenched Nilu with one hand, while still futilely trying to clean her up with the handkerchief in the other, "Rabbi absorbs water well."

Lucretia let out a sigh: "You shouldn't use the fact that you're not afraid of nightmares as an excuse to always pick on Rabbi. I remember you using him to wipe the table last time."

Luni immediately bowed her head in remorse: "Mistress, I apologize."

From her sister's supportive grasp, Nilu cheerfully raised her hand: "Not sorry!"

Lucretia resignedly said, "Forget it, stop wiping. We'll just soak everything in a tub when we get back."

Duncan sat at the table, his arms crossed, a serene smile on his face as he observed the familiar, chaotic scene unfold before him. It reminded him of the time when Alice had proudly presented her fish soup at the dining table, while her head was still bubbling away in the cooking pot.

Soon after, they prepared to depart.

The Vanished and the Bright Star moved slowly but eventually reached the black island adorned with the towering temple and winding paths.

The necessary farewells had been exchanged.

A paper-folded small boat was launched from the edge of the Vanished's deck, unfolding into a shuttle large enough to accommodate everyone. Lucretia stood aboard the small craft, with Luni beside her, clutching Nilu.

Shirley, Dog, Nina, Morris, Vanna, Sailor, and the spectral form of Agatha…

One after another, the figures disembarked from the Vanished, gathering on the paper-folded small boat.

Duncan remained on the deck, silently watching the unfolding scene.

Then, he noticed Nina and Shirley turn around, followed by Vanna, Morris, and the others—their faces adorned with smiles, they waved back at him.

Lucretia wore the brightest smile of all.

At every part of, one should smile, so that if they never met again, the last memory they held of each other would be filled with warmth and joy.

Thus, Duncan too smiled, waving vigorously at each departing member.

And then, they left.

Chapter 828: The End and the Beginning

The Bright Star skillfully navigated farther away from the shore, adjusting its course with a subtle turn. The ancient wheel mechanisms on its sides groaned quietly under the pressure as the ship gained momentum, swiftly slicing through the dense, ominous fog ahead. It sped up, disappearing from sight as it moved further away, eventually fading completely from Duncan's view.

Duncan stayed behind on the Vanished, his gaze locked on the last spot where the Bright Star had been visible before it vanished into the thick fog. He continued to watch long after the ship was gone, his attention only shifting when he noticed a gothic-style doll in an elaborate deep purple dress standing beside him.

The doll, known as Alice, had also been staring off into the distance. Simultaneously with Duncan, she turned her focus elsewhere.

Just then, a plump white dove landed on Alice's shoulder. The dove looked curiously at her with its small, round eyes, reminiscent of mung beans.

The atmosphere on the Vanished had become eerily quiet. The usual chatter and activity that animated the deck were absent. There were no playful arguments between Shirley and Nina, no Morris gazing out to sea lost in thought, no Vanna sitting on a barrel carving amulets, and no sightings of the mysterious Agatha. Only Duncan, the doll, and the dove remained.

After a lengthy silence, Alice murmured, "They're all gone…"

It was unclear to Duncan whether this was an expression of sorrow from the doll or simply an observation.

Reflecting on the departure of the others, Alice had not questioned whether she should stay; she had remained as if it had always been her intention. Her acceptance of the situation intrigued Duncan.

“When everyone else left, you didn’t ask if you could stay,” Duncan noted, looking into the doll’s eyes, “You didn’t even seem to consider it, did you?”

Alice responded with a chuckle, her tone confident, “Of course I had to stay!”

Her response was direct, implying that the decision required no justification.

Duncan paused to consider her words, then laughed and gestured around them, “You see, it seems we’ve come full circle back to the beginning.”

Alice looked around, her realization quick, “Oh, it’s just you and me left on this ship… ah, and Ai, and Mr. Goathead.”

The dove then tilted its head and began to flap its wings vigorously, squawking in a sharp, discordant female voice, “Initializing settings, initializing settings!”

Duncan watched the dove intently, reminded of his homeland by the fact that this bird hailed as a relic from Earth, and replied softly, “…Yes, initializing settings. Time to proceed to the next operation.”

He then turned away and waved to Alice without looking back, “Off we go, Alice, it’s time to fulfill our promise to Gomona.”

“Ah, yes, captain!” Alice responded eagerly.

“Aye, aye, captain!” Ai cooed loudly with her wings flapping.

…

As they continued to sail away, the fog around them grew thicker, swirling like an intricate curtain that seemed to isolate them from the rest of the world. The silhouette of the ship's stern gradually blurred until it completely disappeared into the expansive fog, signaling that the Bright Star had reached the perimeter of the island clusters and was about to vanish entirely from the temple island.

On the highest deck of the Bright Star, Lucretia and others stood, unwilling to break their stares from the encroaching mist until the last familiar contours of their surroundings had faded.

"At first, I thought I was cursed to be trapped on that ship for a lifetime," Shirley confided quietly, visibly shaken by the memory. "But now, we are really leaving it…"

Near her, a clothesline stretched between a railing and a flagpole, from which a small doll named Nilu was hanging. The line ran through the sleeves of her garment, allowing her to sway gently. This little creature, still developing her awareness, sensed the shift in mood and asked timidly, "Mistress… unhappy?"

Lucretia turned towards the swinging doll, her expression softening to a gentle smile, "No, just thinking."

"Thinking!" Nilu repeated, perhaps questioning or simply echoing the last word she heard.

Unbothered by the repetition, Lucretia affirmed quietly to herself, "Yes, thinking, thinking about what to do next. You will think like this too, in the future. Your mind will grow, just like your sister's – you all possess the 'hearts' I meticulously created."

Encouraged by her words, Nilu began swinging more joyfully, exclaiming, “The heart!”

The prolonged silence was broken when Sailor announced, “We are now nearing the physical maritime boundary. Lady Lucretia, any further and we’ll fall into the chaotic time stream. It’s time to enter the next stage of the journey.”

Lucretia nodded slightly, her gaze then shifting to the side.

In the mist, a shadowy female figure appeared, nodding back at Lucretia.

“Miss Agatha, Sailor, I want to thank you both. Go ahead and take over from here.”

“Don’t mention it, it’s all per the captain’s orders,” Agatha responded, her voice ethereal as it floated through the air. Then, her spectral form gradually faded into the mist.

Suddenly, a deep and profound rumbling began within the Bright Star, emanating from beneath their feet. It felt as though a massive beast was stirring in the ship’s hull, its presence rising from the sea’s depths. The rumbling and vibrations spread through the entire vessel as the “reflection of the Vanished,” guided by Agatha, began to physically manifest.

A gigantic phantom emerged from a shadowy realm, swiftly ascending from the calm sea surface. With unstoppable force, it merged into the Bright Star.

Shirley’s eyes widened in awe as she watched the deck ignite with intense, surreal green flames. These flames consumed every part of the ship inch by inch, transforming the towering smokestack into a dark mast, while the steaming vapors morphed into ghostly sails. The wooden deck extended before her, leading to a grand helm and a dark steering wheel at its far end.

For a brief moment, the scene vividly resembled the Vanished, making Shirley feel as if she were back on board her previous ship.

Yet, this was only an illusion, albeit a fleeting one. From up close, Shirley could discern numerous details characteristic of the Bright Star, confirming that they were still aboard it.

However, this level of “projection fusion” was sufficient for Anomaly 077 to assume his role as the “helmsman of the Vanished.”

The gaunt figure, resembling a corpse, solemnly straightened his sailor’s uniform, then nodded at Lucretia and approached the phantom-flamed helm. He climbed the spectral steps to the elevated platform and grasped the dark steering wheel firmly. The hollow howls and echoes, seemingly emanating from the depths of this apparition, soon transformed into celebratory cheers for their homeward voyage.

“Return – home!” Sailor shouted, his voice hoarse and commanding as he forcefully turned the steering wheel, “We’re going home!”

As Duncan traversed the ruins along the “Pilgrimage Path,” a distant howling echoed from the edge of the vast sea, prompting him to pause and glance back towards the source of the spectral sounds.

Alice, walking alongside him, also halted and looked around with curiosity, “What’s the matter?”

Duncan turned to her, his voice low and reflective, “…They’re returning, everything is going smoothly.”

“Is that so? That’s great,” Alice replied, her face lighting up with a smile, “I wonder how Pland is doing now…”

“Pland… is doing well.” Duncan’s response came slowly as he attuned himself to the distant and elusive “signal” that bridged time and space.

He maintained a connection with Pland, whose “avatar” remained active in the antique shop, following his previous instructions. However, Duncan felt the link weakening, not due to any environmental factors or the vast

“remote distance” at the “end of the world.” This fading connection was an inevitable consequence of the “anomaly” known as “Zhou Ming” growing and awakening.

The fragile sanctuary could not endure the intense scrutiny of the “anomaly,” whose gaze, if cast even momentarily across the Boundless Sea, could obliterate it in a mere 0.002 seconds.

That was why he had sent Nina and Morris back to the Boundless Sea—to serve as his “eyes”—since he anticipated losing his own ability to observe it directly.

After a brief moment of tuning in, Duncan carefully managed his dwindling connection to the distant avatars. Sensing the escalating “awakening” within himself, he further diminished the avatars’ activity, now disabling their senses of taste, smell, and their ability to perceive temperature, pain, and other complex sensations inherently human.

These human sensations—feeling warmth or cold, pain, tiredness, and the need for sleep—had once been crucial in maintaining his identity as a human. But now, he had no choice but to gradually shut them off to prolong his observational capabilities of the Boundless Sea.

His goal was to sustain this until Nina was safely back.

“Captain?”

Alice’s concerned voice broke his focus. Duncan turned to see the doll looking at him worriedly, gently tugging at his sleeve.

“Are you okay?” Alice inquired anxiously, “You don’t look very well.”

Duncan’s expression softened gradually.

Even without the sensory feedback from the avatars, he was determined to retain his humanity.

“It’s okay,” he reassured her softly, “Let’s go, they’ve already set off, and we still have a long way to go.”

Chapter 829: An Unexpected Encounter

In a world where everything was bathed in shades of gray and white, the shadowy Mirror Vanished, which veiled the Bright Star, moved silently through the corridor-like expanse. Its massive structure was surrounded by green flames that glowed with a ghostly light, creating a navigational link between the ship and its environment while Anomaly 077 piloted the vessel toward the Boundless Sea.

The voyage back seemed to drag on forever. The monochrome corridor stretched on indefinitely, presenting a dreary landscape devoid of any wind or noise outside the ship. Even though the crew was well-acquainted with this path, it felt as though they were making no progress, caught in an endless journey that everyone on board grew weary of.

The Bright Star functioned both as a cutting-edge exploration vessel and a mobile fortress for the sea witch. It housed numerous dangerous laboratories and workshops, making it a place not conducive to light-hearted pursuits.

Shirley, utterly bored, leaned against the railing, staring into the perpetual gray and white abyss. She mumbled to herself, “When will we ever arrive? It feels like we’ve been aimlessly floating in this void since we set out.”

“You’re not wrong,” Nina agreed, joining Shirley at the railing and letting out a deep sigh. “It does seem like we’ve spent most of our time just drifting here.”

After a brief silence, Shirley confessed, “I kind of miss the captain.”

“It hasn’t been that long since we were last with the captain,” Dog’s muffled voice came from the deck below them. He looked up at Shirley and remarked, “Weren’t you just saying yesterday how relieved you were to be free from someone constantly pestering you about reading and writing?”

“That’s different,” Shirley replied, looking at Dog with a conflicted expression. “I still feel… it’s complicated.”

Dog lowered his head, acknowledging Shirley’s difficulty in expressing her feelings.

Suddenly, an unexpected tremor disrupted their conversation as the deck vibrated briefly.

Dog quickly raised his head, the green flames in his eye sockets flickering wildly. “Did you two feel that? It felt like the deck just shook.”

“Could we be approaching our destination?” Shirley speculated, her gaze shifting towards the horizon. A strange, indistinct line began to materialize within the gray and white. “Look, something is appearing!”

No sooner had Shirley spoken than another, stronger tremor shook the Bright Star. The entire ship trembled, and soft alarm bells rang out from different areas shrouded in the spectral illusion of the Mirror Vanished.

Alarmed, Shirley exchanged a concerned glance with Nina and rushed towards the stern’s control wheel.

As they sprinted, the chains of the dark abyss suddenly tightened, pulling Dog into the air before he could stand. Dangling and bouncing, he shouted, “Hey, Shirley, slow down! At least warn me first! Don’t rush off like this __”

But Shirley didn’t listen. She continued to drag Dog along as she ran across the deck, with Nina moving even quicker, like a swiftly darting flame.

When they reached the control wheel, they discovered Lucretia already there, intently monitoring the situation. Sailor, the helmsman, gripped the wheel tightly, his face marked by nervous confusion.

Nina hurried over to Lucretia and inquired anxiously, “Miss Lucretia, what happened?”

With a serious tone, Lucretia explained, “We are exiting the ‘corridor’ prematurely. We have not yet returned to the Boundless Sea.”

Although Shirley was not an expert in navigation, her experiences sailing the frontier made her acutely aware of the seriousness of their situation. Her eyes widened in alarm, “Ah?! Damn… Exiting prematurely means falling directly into chaos. It could take years to return…”

Lucretia paused, lost in thought for a moment, before addressing Sailor, “What’s the situation now? Can we still control it?”

Sailor responded quickly, “No, the corridor is collapsing, and we are veering off course—it’s as if some massive ‘target’ is interfering with it. I can only maintain the ship’s stability now. Be prepared; we are about to exit!”

Just as Sailor finished his explanation, a violent tremor, stronger and more sudden than the earlier ones, shook the Bright Star violently. It seemed as if the ship was flung several meters into the air before crashing back down onto the sea. Amid the thunderous roar, even Lucretia nearly stumbled. Simultaneously, the uniform gray and white ‘corridor’ seemed to rip apart from the force, disappearing from view.

Within seconds, an immense expanse of dense, chaotic fog surrounded them. Outside, a mirror-smooth sea surface shrouded in mist appeared. The

Bright Star found itself adrift in this obscured ‘sea,’ directionless and unable to identify any landmarks or determine its position.

Visibly shaken, Shirley stared into the distance at the thick fog typical of the frontier seas and sighed deeply, “Ah, it’s over, we are still at the frontier…”

Lucretia, frowning and with a tone laden with concern, added, “Even worse, we’re not just at the frontier but outside the six-mile limit.” She peered into the swirling fog and continued, “If we were inside the six-mile limit, there might still be a chance to catch the civilized world’s radio signals, or at least find a way to ‘navigate’ back to the Boundless Sea. But beyond it…”

Sailor cut in grimly, “This time, ‘direction’ is completely useless.”

Agatha, materializing like a misty, ethereal figure on the deck, approached with an understanding of their plight and asked about their next steps, “Miss Lucretia, should we temporarily disengage the projection of the Vanished?”

After a moment’s consideration, Lucretia decided, “No, keep it for now. Although it’s just a projection, it’s still the shadow of the Vanished, which can provide some protection to the Bright Star in this eerie sea… Are you under a lot of stress?”

“I’m fine,” Agatha reassured her, shaking her head, “I can maintain it for a few more days easily. But it can’t be maintained indefinitely.”

“I understand,” Lucretia acknowledged gently. Her attention then shifted to something flickering deep within the fog—perhaps a ship’s lamp, or just an illusory glimmer of hope?

“There’s something there!” Shirley exclaimed, her excitement palpable as she jumped up and pointed into the distance. “There’s something flashing over there!”

“Head that way,” Lucretia decided after a brief moment of contemplation.

She knew this decision was somewhat impulsive. This area, the frontier beyond the crucial six-mile limit, was not governed by the protective influence of the Four Gods' nodes or the temporal and spatial safeguards known as "navigation lines." Any phenomena they encountered here could be perilous—be it a transient breeze, a deceptive illusion, or a siren-like whisper.

Venturing towards an unidentified presence in this frontier zone carried significant risks. Yet, with the Bright Star having prematurely exited the navigational corridor and now hopelessly adrift beyond the essential boundary, swallowed by a relentless dense fog and possibly surrounded by emerging time rifts and enigmatic "entities" that could be just as dangerous, they seemed to have no other option.

The flickering light in the fog might be a "drifting object" that had originated within the six-mile limit, and approaching it could potentially offer a route back to the Boundless Sea.

Guided by Sailor's skilled handling, the Bright Star, surrounded by spectral flames, slowly adjusted its course, inching closer to the shimmering light deep within the fog.

As they approached, the light remained consistent, growing clearer instead of dissipating into the mist.

Lucretia breathed a sigh of relief, but her anxiety soon surged anew.

The light was real, not an illusion—it was a tangible entity, a mysterious object drifting through the fog-laden sea…

What kind of ominous object could it be?

Lucretia glanced back toward the deck, reassured by the thought that under the protective guise of the Vanished's mirrored counterpart, combined with

the Bright Star’s formidable arsenal and unique capabilities, they were well-prepared to face whatever awaited them.

Her father’s critical mission was far from complete, and she was resolute not to perish en route home for an unknown cause.

Other crew members emerged from below deck and gathered on the aft deck, quickly catching up on the situation through the updates provided by Shirley and Nina. They too began to anxiously watch the light as it grew steadily clearer through the dense fog.

Suddenly, as if the fog momentarily thinned, the light and the silhouette behind it became distinctly visible.

Using the lens embedded in his face, Morris was the first to make out the shape behind the light, and his expression subtly changed.

It was a ship.

A frontier exploration vessel, distinguished by the unique features of a paddle wheel power system and a ghostly half-body.

It was the Bright Star.

A silence fell over the deck, and after a short pause, many eyes turned to Lucretia.

“…It looks familiar,” Shirley murmured quietly.

Snapping out of her daze, Lucretia realized—

“That’s the Bright Star… from a long time ago, when I first crossed the critical six-mile limit.”

Chapter 830: Hesitation at the Threshold

Lucretia instantly recognized the ship; it was her own vessel, the Bright Star, yet it belonged to an alternate timeline.

Decades earlier, during a daring voyage near the borders, Lucretia had inadvertently crossed the boundary and became “lost” on the Bright Star. At that exact moment, decades in the past, she stood aboard that ship, desperately seeking a way back to the Boundless Seas.

Sailor, clutching the wheel and sweating profusely (assuming his sweat glands still functioned), instinctively shouted, “Lady! That’s an vessel from another timeline—do not go near it! We likely got knocked out of the ‘channel’ prematurely because of its interference. Any rash contact could trap us!”

Prompted by Sailor’s warning, the crew on deck began to understand that this encounter was unlike any previous interactions, such as the one with the Sea Song in the “channel.”

The Sea Song was a ship unconnected to the Vanished or the Bright Star, and its sudden appearance at that time was just a fleeting phantom caused by temporal disturbances. However, the ship now materializing from the dense fog was indeed the Bright Star from a different timeline, a “parallel space counterpart” to their own vessel. The implications of contact between two such ships within the temporal flow were uncertain.

No scholar, even those from the Truth Academy skilled in physical and combat arts, had explored this phenomenon, but it was clear that the outcome would likely be dire.

Yet Lucretia seemed to disregard Sailor's urgent warning. She gazed intently at the Bright Star as it drew closer through the fog. Suddenly, as if struck by a realization, she quickly surveyed her surroundings.

The illusion of the Vanished overlaid the ship, its dark wooden deck aglow with ghostly spirit fires, and translucent spirit sails billowing from the masts —all as vivid in her memory as the day it happened.

On this final journey at the edge of the world, she finally grasped the enduring mystery that even her "father" had failed to unravel.

It was she herself, steering her own destiny…

"Don't worry," she spoke softly, her voice not loud, but carrying enough weight to quiet the entire deck, "We won't meet that ship—we'll just pass by it. Keep to our current course, sail beside it, without making any contact."

"Okay… Just make sure that 'you' on that ship doesn't suddenly come closer," Sailor murmured softly. He didn't challenge the "captain's" judgment at that moment; instead, he obeyed the order, piloting their "hybrid" vessel, slowly steering alongside the Bright Star.

Tension gripped everyone on board as they observed the Bright Star emerging from the dense fog of another temporal stream. It was close enough for them to make out numerous details on its hull, spotting many variances that seemed to mark it as a "version" from decades past. They watched anxiously as the other ship momentarily slowed and faltered as if the sudden proximity to the Vanished caused a brief stir of panic. Ultimately, the two ships passed by each other without incident.

Lucretia exhaled a deep sigh of relief.

Then, in the moments after the ships had completely passed one another, the Bright Star from the alternate time stream quickly faded, vanishing like a phantom into the fog.

The convergence of the time streams had concluded.

This was the moment Lucretia had anticipated. She immediately commanded, “Turn the ship around, follow the last trace of that ship as it disappeared; that’s our direction back to the Boundless Seas.”

Sailor internally hesitated, yet his hands moved swiftly to carry out the captain’s order. As the ship began to slowly adjust its course, he turned to glance at the “sea witch”: “Lady, was that…”

“That was something that happened once, decades ago, beyond the critical boundary. The Bright Star once encountered the ‘illusion’ of the Vanished. I still remember every detail,” Lucretia nodded, “Don’t dwell on it too much; first, figure out how to leave this place.”

“It’s no use thinking too hard; my head is about to explode,” Shirley said, scratching her head. She quickly reviewed the situation in her mind, clearly overwhelmed, “So, you from decades ago got lost at the border, encountering a guiding illusion that was actually you from the future, but even your future self was lost – neither ship knew the way back, but both eventually found the right direction… What is even happening here?”

“Causality, luck, space-time, everything here is a mess,” Morris remarked, holding a seldom-lit pipe in his mouth, his voice carrying a hint of somberness, “Don’t rely too heavily on rationality when thinking about the border seas. The human brain has its limits when it comes to ‘irrationality.’ Don’t let those irrational things drive you mad.”

As the old man finished speaking, Dog grumbled under his breath nearby, “Shirley’s fine, she doesn’t overthink things, her mind is as clear as day.”

Shirley reacted to Dog’s comment by punching him on the head, resulting in a resounding ‘clang’.

Lucretia and the helmsman, immersed in their duties, paid no attention to the minor disturbance beside them. They remained sharply focused on the path ahead, guided by the direction indicated by the bow of the Bright Star, where the fog appeared to be shifting ominously.

Noticing a change, Nina looked up in concern, “Miss Lucretia, why are we slowing down now?”

Lucretia responded with calm precision, “…There’s a ‘critical change’ ahead in the fog, that marks the boundary. Crossing that line will take us into the relatively safe waters of the Eternal Veil,” she explained, her tone then growing more serious, “But there’s a problem.”

While Nina looked confused, the helmsman seemed to have already grasped the situation. He grimaced, making a grinding noise with his mouth, “Once we ‘cross’ from that point, our date of return to the Boundless Seas will be set – but that might not align with a date like 1902.”

Nina’s confusion lasted only a moment before realization dawned, and her eyes widened as she understood the helmsman’s implication.

Lucretia added gravely, “We exited the ‘channel’ too soon, and the moment we deviated from our navigation path, the surrounding time streams likely became disrupted,” she explained. “And just now, the Bright Star from decades ago appearing could indicate a shadow from another time stream intersecting our path, or it could mean we’ve inadvertently ‘entered’ the wrong time stream…”

This time, even Shirley grasped the gravity of their situation, her shock evident, “That means, if we go back now, we might end up decades ago?!”

The helmsman sighed deeply, “That would be the better scenario. Worse yet, with the time streams so jumbled, we could end up at any point in time after we cross the boundary.”

Shirley exclaimed, “…Damn…”

“Should we contact the captain?” Vanna suddenly suggested, recognizing their predicament’s gravity, “This is already beyond what was planned; maybe the captain’s authority could…”

“No, I’ve already tried,” Lucretia interrupted, shaking her head, “but I could only vaguely sense my father’s voice.” She continued, “We are still in the chaotic flux at the border, where the disordered temporal flow creates interference, and from my father’s perspective…”

She paused, then shook her head slightly again, indicating uncertainty and concern.

The crew members exchanged uneasy glances as the Bright Star continued its cautious navigation near the ‘critical line’ within the fog, moving slowly through what was deemed a ‘safer’ zone, avoiding the fog’s deeper, more perilous parts.

The path home appeared deceptively simple as if they could merely step across it—no physical barriers, no visible obstructions lay in their way. Yet, the true obstacle for the Bright Star was far more daunting than any physical barrier—it was time itself.

On the bridge, the mechanical intricacies of the ship were diligently monitored by Luni, a clockwork automaton. Tucked away in a corner, Rabbit Rabbi held tightly to the doll Nilu, barely daring to breathe. Agatha’s silhouette was faintly visible in the reflection of a nearby porthole, and the

rest were gathered around the captain’s chair, creating a palpably tense atmosphere.

“If only there was a ‘guiding anchor’ from the Boundless Seas,” Morris whispered, his voice low, “even a simple piece of driftwood from the Veil would suffice.”

“The likelihood of that isn’t any greater than us crossing the boundary and landing precisely in the year 1902,” Lucretia responded, shaking her head dismissively. “We’re at the border, after all.”

Shirley rubbed her head, her voice tinged with uncertainty, “Imagine if we really ended up decades, even centuries, millennia in the past…”

She trailed off, leaving her sentence hanging in the air.

Vanna quietly echoed Shirley’s unfinished thought, “Centuries…”

“That would mean we arrived ‘too early’,” Nina quipped, sticking out her tongue playfully, “The good news would be that we could see the ‘sun’ as it was back then.”

Vanna, however, ignored Nina’s attempt at humor and looked up earnestly at Lucretia, “Miss Lucretia, how long can you survive?”

The bridge fell eerily silent. Lucretia understood the gravity of Vanna’s question and broke the silence after a moment of solemn contemplation, “I’m not certain how enduring this ‘curse’ might be, but living for a few centuries shouldn’t pose a problem.”

Morris shook his head, his tone somber, “My life is finite. Even with the aid of mechanics and wisdom, this body will eventually degrade.”

From the side, Agatha’s voice added, “Theoretically, I have no lifespan limit but without a physical form to inhabit, my existence remains precarious…”

“Shadow demons can live very long,” Vanna suddenly turned to Shirley, “At least, I’ve never heard of one dying from ‘old age’. They just need to stay hidden, especially from the church guardians of any given era…”

Shirley listened, her expression turning from blank to slowly dawning comprehension, “Ah… no way…”

“We need to prepare for the worst-case scenario,” Vanna stated firmly.

“Then consider an even grimmer possibility,” Lucretia interjected, her expression serious, “What if we didn’t arrive too early, but ‘too late’? When Father needs us, we might not have arrived yet…”

A heavy silence descended upon the group once again.

The oppressive quiet hung over the bridge, stifling conversation.

But suddenly, a ringing sound emanated from the direction of the control wheel, piercing the heavy atmosphere.

At that moment, the clockwork automaton Luni, ever vigilant at the monitoring area, exclaimed with urgency, “Lady, there’s a signal!”

Chapter 831: Silent Calls

A signal was detected!

An immediate hush enveloped the bridge. Even Lucretia, typically the paragon of self-control, registered a brief flicker of surprise in her eyes—a signal had been detected six miles beyond the frontier's boundary. In this disconcerting situation, maintaining composure proved challenging for everyone where they were lost.

"How is there a signal out here? Who could be sending it? Is this a real signal or just another deceitful trap set by the thick fog to ensnare us?" Lucretia questioned the air.

"Prepare defenses!" Lucretia commanded without a second thought. She darted to the control panel and swiftly pulled a lever among the assortment of devices. Luni, positioned close by, reacted with equal urgency. Her clockwork doll pressed several buttons on the console and then pulled back, winding the spring on her back in reverse three full turns.

Soft clicking noises filled the air as tiny cracks formed on Luni's arms, legs, and neck. Runes began to illuminate beneath her synthetic skin, and her eyes emitted a soft red glow. Simultaneously, mechanical sounds resonated around them as grids and conduits, previously hidden, slid out from the floor and walls, releasing the scent of incense and a deep, resonant hum.

Shirley watched in awe and eventually exclaimed, "Wow… you even have this incredible contraption?!"

Nina, equally astonished, stared at the now defensively positioned clockwork doll. “How did you transform like that?”

Under Nina’s intense scrutiny, Luni trembled slightly, the sound of clashing internal components evident. “I must emphasize, my mistress has forbidden any disassembly by strangers,” she stated as she eyed the girl warily.

“Exploring the frontier regularly requires us to be perpetually prepared for the unexpected,” Lucretia noted, her gaze shifting towards the demon girl and the mini sun fragment. She sighed softly, “Stay alert; I’m about to connect to this signal. The entity trying to communicate might not be human, or even capable of normal speech… But that probably doesn’t scare either of you.”

As she finished, Lucretia took a deep breath and laid her hand on the communicator—click.

A voice, burdened with heavy static and distortion as if filtered through multiple layers of interference, emanated from the speaker: “…Calling… zzzz…this is…zzzz…the lighthouse, calling…the Vanished, awaiting your…zzzz…return. Repeat, this is…zzzz…”

The monotone, raspy message echoed like a ghost caught between moments in time.

Everyone on the bridge, including Lucretia, momentarily froze in shock.

“Lighthouse?” Shirley whispered to herself after a pause, her memory suddenly stirring, “Wait, I remember now! When we left, the last stop…”

Lucretia’s thoughts wandered back to the last mobile harbor on the frontier before their fleet crossed the veil, remembering the female pope’s farewell: “Three warships will stay near the lighthouse, awaiting your return… This harbor will remain here, and my avatar will stay until you return…”

“…The lighthouse is still operational, they’re actually still waiting there?!” Shirley’s eyes widened in realization. She might not have been the most studious, but her memory was sharp. “It seems like the whole world is almost frozen in time!”

Lucretia remained silent, pondering their departure. She maintained her usual composure, unaffected by the excitement of the moment. She first confirmed that the signal was real and not a mirage created by the crew’s collective psyche reflecting off the frontier waters. She then checked the Bright Star’s defenses before lifting the radio handset: “This is the Bright Star. We have received your message. We are attempting to navigate back from the critical line. Our ship’s navigation is down. Please boost the power of the lighthouse’s antenna.”

She replaced the handset and waited.

However, only static responded from the communicator, followed by a few seconds of the same repetitive message, then silence took over, leaving only the buzz of interference.

“Can’t they hear us?” Nina asked, eyes wide with curiosity, “Is there interference?”

“I’m not sure, but it’s clear that the signal definitely originated from ‘the lighthouse,’” Lucretia replied, her brow furrowed. She turned to Luni, “Can you determine the signal’s direction?”

“Not precisely, but I can estimate a general direction,” Luni responded promptly, adjusting the nearby equipment, “Should we head that way?”

Lucretia exchanged a glance with Morris.

After a silent agreement, they decided to follow this signal as their “guiding anchor” back home—a metaphorical piece of driftwood from beyond the boundary.

“We’ll at least make it back to around the year 1902,” Lucretia murmured to herself.

The Bright Star cautiously adjusted its trajectory, patrolling along the six-mile critical boundary as long as possible, and increased the sensitivity of its antenna to pinpoint the signal’s direction. They eventually identified the most probable “gap” in the boundary line.

The ship’s horn blared with determined resolve as the Bright Star, shrouded in the ghostly image of the Mirror Vanished, plunged into the mist toward home.

As they crossed the critical line, the crew felt almost nothing, but Lucretia, seasoned in navigating the frontier seas, subtly sensed an indescribable “change.”

Her expression tense and her senses sharpened, Lucretia was acutely aware of every sound emanating from the communicator—

Had they made it back? Were they now around the year 1902?

As if fate had finally ceased its mischievous antics upon their return, Luni joyfully reported just as they crossed the threshold: “Mistress, the signal has significantly strengthened—we’ve successfully re-entered the veil, and we’ve also received a precise time signal, confirming our timing is accurate!”

Lucretia let out a deep sigh of relief. The last time she had felt such profound relief and happiness was when she received her brother’s message confirming that their “father has indeed regained his humanity.”

The bridge erupted in cheers from Shirley and Nina, accompanied by the relieved sighs of Rabbi in the corner and the quiet jubilation of the little doll, Nilu.

“Continue closing in on the signal,” Lucretia commanded, picking up the radio handset again to contact the lighthouse, “This is the Bright Star, we have successfully crossed the critical line, advancing toward the lighthouse, is your situation secure?”

However, after calling twice, only static noise filled the air. Although the signal was now strong enough not to disrupt communications, the lighthouse still gave no response.

It almost seemed as though the earlier call beckoning them home had been nothing but an illusion.

Lucretia’s face grew more serious, and the bridge’s atmosphere, which had briefly lightened, turned tense once again.

She set down the handset, shaking her head, “Something seems off about the lighthouse, we’ll head there first and investigate.”

As they approached, the lighthouse emerged from the depths of the frontier fog near the six-mile critical line, its ability to transmit signals through the veil somewhat diminished but still active.

It was still illuminated, the beacon less bright than at their departure but still cutting through the dense fog.

The sight of the light allowed a slight easing of tension. There was an active signal, and the light was still operational, suggesting the recent lighthouse maintenance.

But why was there such silence?

After a prolonged journey, the Bright Star finally drew near to the lighthouse.

At first sight, Lucretia observed the three massive Storm Church warships still moored quietly under the lighthouse at the mobile platform’s harbor.

Their lights were still lit and clearly operational, yet they offered no response to the Bright Star's arrival.

It appeared as though the ships were being maintained, but no one was acknowledging their return.

"I think I saw someone moving in the upper sections of the lighthouse," Shirley commented, peering intently from the deck, her voice barely above a whisper, "There are definitely people up there, but it seems like they're ignoring us… Can't they see us?"

"Could all this actually be just an illusion…" Nina voiced her concerns softly.

"…What if we're the illusion?" Shirley added, her suggestion carrying an even more eerie undertone.

Lucretia, however, paid little heed to the girls' speculative whispering. She too had noticed signs of activity within the lighthouse. After a moment of contemplation, she decisively laid out her plan:

"I'll go up with Vanna to investigate. Everyone else, stay on the ship. Do not disembark until we return, and be wary of any voices or figures that might appear on the communicator. Luni, keep watch over the ship."

Luni promptly nodded in acknowledgment: "Yes, Mistress."

With their plans quickly set, Lucretia and Vanna embarked on a paper boat, making a discreet landing at the eerily quiet lighthouse.

The surrounding area was steeped in silence, the cold wind sweeping through the harbor brought a piercing chill that seemed to freeze the soul and stiffen the blood.

Stepping onto the pier's walkway, Lucretia and Vanna surveyed their surroundings in the enveloping night mist. Shadows and figures moved

within the mist, yet strangely, none seemed to acknowledge their presence.

Chapter 832: Welcome Home

Lucretia and Vanna traversed the moving platform beneath the lighthouse complex, navigating the dense fog along well-known paths and bridges during the night. The weak lighting around them shone like distant, dim stars in the mist. Amidst the soft glow and shadows, a figure stirred nearby.

A harbor guard, his complexion ghostly white, brushed past Vanna. He was dressed in a sharp uniform and held a lantern that still shone brightly. His face was marked by a precise, careful expression, yet he seemed completely unaware of the two unexpected visitors in his path.

As the guard disappeared back into the fog, Vanna observed him with a troubled expression. Once he was out of sight, she turned to Lucretia and whispered, “He wasn’t breathing.”

“Yes, the person we saw earlier wasn’t either. Most here no longer breathe,” Lucretia replied quietly, her face cast in shadows, “Even those few who still breathe show no signs of noticing our presence.”

“Everyone seems to be in a state of…” Vanna started, struggling to find the right words, then paused, finding it difficult to articulate her feelings. After a moment, she resumed, “A sort of stupor, a pervasive ‘unawareness.’ They continue with their routines, even handling shifts with precision, but they don’t acknowledge us at all.”

Lucretia just hummed softly and didn’t respond further, instead surveying the shadowy surroundings through the fog before they made their way toward the church at the lighthouse’s base.

Inside the church, the atmosphere was similarly subdued, with fewer people around. Apart from a few individuals sitting or praying quietly, only a priestess in a black nun's outfit was present, cleaning the main hall. She appeared slightly more aware of Vanna and Lucretia's presence, pausing and looking their way briefly before resuming her task nonchalantly just as Vanna was about to address her.

Lucretia and Vanna then walked across the church's main hall and entered the tower that connected to the lighthouse through a side door. They climbed a dimly lit spiral staircase, checking several vacant restrooms and storage areas until they came upon a door left slightly open.

From behind the door emanated a bright light and a soft sizzling noise.

Vanna moved to push the slightly open door further and entered a small room filled with various devices, the air fragrant with incense. In the center of the room, a small brass incense burner hung from a steam pipe, seemingly freshly lit.

As they passed by the steam pipe, almost in unison, a figure rose from a corner of the room and walked directly towards Lucretia.

Lucretia was taken aback when the figure stood up, previously unnoticed in the corner of the room. It was a middle-aged man clad in a priest's robe, who eerily lacked any signs of breathing or a heartbeat. He appeared completely unaware of their presence, almost like an inanimate object, so much so that Vanna hadn't even realized there was another person in the room.

Without acknowledging them, the priest passed by Lucretia and Vanna with an expressionless demeanor and sat down at a table at the far end of the room. His movements were mechanical as if he were programmed to perform these actions. Clearing his throat, he pressed a button on the table and positioned a microphone in front of him.

“Calling Vanished, calling Bright Star, this is the border lighthouse. The current time is the twelfth month of 1902. We await your return voyage… Repeat, calling the voyagers, this is the border lighthouse, the current time is… we await your return…”

He repeated the message three times, then paused and pressed the button again to repeat it several times before switching the device to listening mode. Afterward, he stood up from the table and returned to his original spot, passing Lucretia and Vanna again without even a glance to the side.

“That’s the call we heard,” Vanna said, watching the scene unfold. She spoke softly, turning towards Lucretia, who was also observing intently.

“I had heard my father describe the Boundless Sea, but I never fully imagined what it would be like,” Lucretia shared, her voice tinged with complexity, “It’s even more… more…”

She faltered, struggling to find the right words to convey her feelings.

“…The situation inside the city-state shouldn’t be this severe,” Vanna commented after a moment, shaking her head slightly. “This lighthouse is in the deepest part of the border, where order dissolved the earliest and where the influence of the gods’ ‘corruption’ is strongest. In the city-state…”

“Yes, the conditions might be better there, although they will likely worsen over time,” Lucretia interjected seriously, “Let’s not dwell on it too much for now.”

“Right, let’s not dwell on it too much now,” Vanna agreed, pausing briefly to gather her thoughts and suppress her worries. Just then, footsteps echoed from outside the room.

The two instinctively turned their heads as the previously ajar door was pushed open by a man in a guardian’s uniform.

He might have been searching for the middle-aged priest.

As Vanna had grown used to the peculiar “environment” of this place, she stepped aside to let someone pass, but just as she did, the guard dressed in black reacted with a sudden startled expression. It seemed he had only just noticed the two women in the room. His body trembled slightly, followed by a look of sheer excitement and joy.

“Miss Vanna, and Lady Lucretia!” the guard exclaimed with enthusiasm, rubbing his eyes as though in disbelief, “Is it really you? Have you returned?!”

Vanna was visibly confused by his reaction, taken aback for a few seconds before her expression shifted to one of surprise: “You’re still ‘awake’?”

“Awake?” The guardian initially looked puzzled but quickly caught on to her meaning. He checked himself, glanced at the other figure resting in the corner of the room, and smiled with a mixture of emotions, “Yes, I am awake, and there are others who are awake too. Everyone would be thrilled to see you…”

“Are there other ‘awake’ people?” Lucretia interjected, clearly surprised, “On our way here…”

“Yes, the awake are few, so we’ve gathered in the residential area below the lighthouse for mutual support and to monitor each other’s condition. We only venture out to patrol, restock supplies, and assist any others who awaken,” the guardian explained with calm precision, “And… to see if you had returned.”

He paused, his gaze shifting to the middle-aged priest seated in the corner of the room.

“The communication device is now controlled by ‘them,’ and disrupting their routine can provoke severe reactions, sometimes even madness. Therefore, we only approach during specific ‘window periods’ to check the

monitoring antenna's records and verify if any ships are navigating back through the deep fog from the top of the lighthouse. Today, it's my shift. But honestly…"

The guard's smile was tinged with complexity and joy: "Honestly, I never thought I'd actually witness your return. I look out at that fog every day, but it's always just fog. Have all of you returned? What's the situation like at the world's end?"

Vanna and Lucretia exchanged looks, and after a brief hesitation, Lucretia nodded slowly, "The situation is quite complex now, and explaining it would take some time. Please, take us to your 'shelter' first."

"Of course," the guardian responded immediately, nodding, "But before you enter the shelter, you'll need to undergo a ritual inspection – it's necessary, given this is the border, and you're returning from the fog."

"After that, Her Grace Helena's avatar will personally welcome you."

Vanna's expression brightened at the mention: "The Pope's avatar is here?"

"She was originally stationed at the mobile port where the Eternal Veil and Boundless Sea meet, but she moved here when the situation deteriorated. Her presence has been crucial in maintaining the shelter—she's been with us throughout this ordeal," explained the black-clad guardian, gesturing invitingly before leading Vanna and Lucretia towards the exit.

As they approached the doorway, the guard halted abruptly, turning to face the two travelers who had just returned from the edge of the world. His expression, initially filled with joy and excitement, gradually softened into a warm smile.

"Although the situation at 'home' is far from ideal right now…" he said earnestly, "welcome home—it's been a tough journey."

Vanna returned his smile: "Yes, we've come back."

…

Upon receiving Lucretia’s message again, Duncan finally felt a sense of relief.

He and Alice were still on the island of the Leviathan Queen, where they had been for several days.

Now, the island was engulfed in flames that shimmered like stardust, creating an illusion reminiscent of a star-forming nebula. These “flames,” mimicking the faint mist emitted by a nebula, enveloped the entire dark island. They seeped from every crack in the stones, each joint between bricks, and from every pillar and rooftop, saturating everything on the island and even spreading to the surrounding sea, reaching the carcasses of the Leviathan-like islands.

Duncan sat calmly on a large stone at the edge of the plaza in front of the black temple, his eyes fixed on the flames as they infused the very “foundation” of this world.

Behind him stood Alice, silent and still.

Chapter 833: Their Last Journey

In a world where the stars burned with the intensity of distant fires on the edge of reality, Duncan-Zhou Ming witnessed the faint sparks he had placed at each corner of the external barrier merging into a glowing ring.

These sparks radiated starlight, enveloping the ancient deities that formed the node points of the barrier. They melded with the gods' power, essence, memories, and information…

This fusion echoed his first encounter with the golden sun mask, during which he unearthed hidden truths by imbuing it with his own fiery essence. In a similar fashion, he had manipulated mystical objects with his flames, and was now applying this method on a much larger scale.

Throughout its existence, from its birth to its decline, the information of this world flowed into his consciousness.

For Duncan, perceiving through the "Counter-Singularity" perspective, the Boundless Sea resembled a magical artifact—this dwindling civilization stubbornly persisted, pretending to be more than a mere pile of ashes.

Alice looked up at Duncan, her eyes filled with curiosity. "Captain, how much longer must we wait here?"

"We can leave now," Duncan responded softly. "Nina and the rest have safely made it back to the Boundless Sea. It's time for us to move on to our next location."

Curious, Alice inquired, “The next place? You haven’t yet told me where that is…”

“It’s a location we must uncover ourselves—but it won’t be hard,” Duncan assured her, then glanced at an object near him.

In his hands, he held an ancient, intricately designed hourglass, a vestige bequeathed by the god of death, Bartok, to the storm goddess, Gomona. He had retrieved this hourglass from a temple just three days earlier.

The sand within, representing life force, was nearly exhausted.

Cradling the hourglass, Duncan watched a gentle flame flicker inside. The final grains of sand hovered within the central flame, defying gravity. He listened to their soft, barely audible murmurs, then nodded slightly: “Yes, it’s time to go.”

These whispers seemed to send him off, though their exact phrases were barely discernible.

Duncan appeared to understand their intent and began to smile warmly: “Ah, that sounds delightful… To reunite with friends, to embark on new adventures, to establish a vibrant group… and maybe even start a souvenir shop?”

“Alright, I understand. I’ll make it happen… Don’t fret or doubt; this is a unique opportunity to influence the world and the future—you all deserve this chance.”

“…Yes, it will take a considerable amount of time, indeed, but don’t worry, I have all the time in the world; it’s merely a blink of an eye to me…”

“Now, we must depart, Gomona, farewell—sweet dreams.”

As he spoke, the final grains of sand disappeared within the flame, and the hourglass silently crumbled to dust, scattering into the breeze. The entire

island commenced its slow submersion beneath the celestial flames.

Knowing its time, Duncan stood up, waved his hand, and magically opened the fiery portal. Moments later, they were back aboard the Vanished. Under the guidance of Goathead, the ship sailed smoothly through the fog that lay between the Leviathan Islands, edging closer to the outer limits of the node sea.

Inside the captain's quarters, Goathead, the ever-diligent first mate, sat by the sea chart table. As the door swung open, Goathead turned around. Seizing the brief moment before possibly being interrupted, Goathead sighed and began to speak hurriedly:

"Ah, it's really a bit hard to adjust to the silence here. Normally, Miss Vanna would be exercising on the deck, and Shirley and Dog would be 'exploring' around. I used to think they were too noisy, always wondering when it would finally be quiet. But now that it's suddenly silent, it feels strange. It's like how it was when I first came aboard this ship; it's amazing how quickly time has passed. The human heart is indeed peculiar; I never imagined I'd go through so much back then. Of course, now I can't really claim to have a good human heart anymore… I'm done talking, I'll be quiet now."

Feeling the words press at him, Duncan had been just about to tell Goathead to be quiet but found himself holding back his words, merely staring at the table momentarily before blurting out, "You're able to be quiet on your own?"

With its usual lack of expression, Goathead responded, "Yes, I just finished speaking."

Duncan, slightly taken aback and suspecting that Goathead's timing was intentional, managed to keep his cool and stated, "…Then continue to remain silent here, Alice and I need to plan our next navigation steps."

Goathead simply acknowledged, “Understood.”

Feeling a mix of irritation and bemusement, Duncan led the conversation deeper into the captain’s room, approaching the bedroom when he whispered to Alice, “Remind me later, I need to establish a rule in the new world—those who speak incessantly without pausing deserve a flick on the tongue…”

Alice leaned closer and whispered back, “But Mr. Goathead doesn’t have a tongue, its voice comes directly from its neck…”

As Duncan entered the bedroom, he casually shut the door behind him and turned to Alice, “Now that you mention it, I’m curious, do you have a tongue?”

“Yes,” Alice responded earnestly, opening her mouth and stretching the corners with her fingers to show him, “Look—plurr plurr, here’s my tongue.”

“I’m really curious how the original Navigator One managed to ‘create’ you, even including a tongue. Couldn’t they have just focused on reinforcing the joints?” Duncan eyed the doll curiously, then approached the bedside, retrieving the winding key for the “Navigator Edition Alice Mansion,” and playfully waved it in front of the doll.

Alice, adeptly managing the task, sat down in front of Duncan, turned her back to him, and unzipped her dress to reveal the keyhole for winding.

Duncan, holding the navigator key, hesitated before using it. He looked at the keyhole on Alice’s back and spoke thoughtfully, “Alice, have you ever thought about wanting something more? Like a desire or a wish… to no longer be a ‘doll’?”

Alice adjusted her dress and turned her head back in slight confusion, asking, “No, what’s wrong with being a doll?”

“Do you have any desires or ideas about the new world and the future?” Duncan continued seriously. “Nina and the others have their dreams—Shirley wants a vast space, Morris desires room for research and exploration, even the Leviathan Queen has her own ambitions. But you… you’ve always been quiet during our discussions about the new world.”

Alice pondered for a moment, then shook her head, saying, “I don’t really have an opinion. I’m not dissatisfied with anything; everything as it is suits me fine,” she said earnestly. “I don’t know what the new world should contain; everything I’ve experienced since ‘waking up’ has been good. And I actually enjoy being a doll, I like it this way.”

After a brief pause, she added, “Ah, but if I choose something to want, I still want to be with you in the new world—I’m not comfortable living in the city-states.”

Duncan’s face showed a mix of surprise and gentle resignation as he smiled.

“Okay,” he responded softly, patting Alice’s hair. “I’ll make sure you come with me, that’s guaranteed. If you’re unsure of what you want, leave it to me, I’ll think about it and make it happen for you.”

“Great!” Alice exclaimed cheerfully, adjusting her position on the bed to turn around, then suddenly she remembered something and turned her head back with a smile, “Oh right, I would like a new frying pan, a smaller one, for making tiny sweet pancakes.”

“Okay, I’ve made a note of that,” Duncan replied with a gentle smile, nodding earnestly, “In the new world, Alice wants a new frying pan.”

“For making small sweet pancakes!”

“Yes, for making small sweet pancakes.”

He inserted the winding key into the keyhole; it clicked into place and turned automatically—light and shadow danced around them, resetting the

ambiance. When Duncan opened his eyes, he found himself back at the starting point before leaving the Alice Mansion.

In the dimly lit main hall of Navigator Three, a “tree” constructed from cables, pipes, and metal branches stood quietly. At its base, a doll holding a drawing board slowly opened her eyes, powering on like a robot, becoming alert, and then smiling brightly.

“Captain! We’re back in!”

Duncan nodded, assisting the slightly unsteady doll to her feet.

“Captain, what are we doing next? Should we greet the Black Sun at the door? Do you want to find the entry… the next route you mentioned?”

Duncan glanced at the “drawing board” in Alice’s hands, now serving as the remaining “functional interface” of Navigator Three.

“We need to search for something,” he started.

“Search for what?”

“The escape pod of the New Hope—it’s lost at the end of the ashes.”

Chapter 834: The True Appearance of the Mansion

After receiving the captain's directives, Alice started pondering with great intent – then she gazed deeply into Duncan's eyes, seeking understanding. "What is an escape pod?" she inquired with genuine curiosity.

Duncan was not taken aback by her question. In fact, he often thought he would only truly worry if this doll ceased to exhibit her characteristic confusion. Despite several mishaps, he had ascertained that although Alice often appeared bewildered, the sophisticated space navigation system, "Navigator Two," was invariably operational within her instinctive knowledge.

At this moment, the task was straightforward: Alice needed to recognize that a segment of the mansion was absent, at least theoretically.

"That's a part that's missing from the 'Alice's Mansion,' but you don't need to understand exactly what it is," Duncan explained nonchalantly, observing her still fixated on him with wide, innocent eyes. "Do you remember what I told you about the Frost Queen?"

Alice paused to reflect. "Which one? There are many, but I don't remember all…"

"Ray Nora has taken a room from your 'Mansion.' That room is what I referred to as the escape pod. She now 'rides' it to the ash-covered edge of the world. I need to locate her position," Duncan elaborated with patience.

“It’s okay if you don’t grasp it all right now; I’ll help you understand this in time.”

Alice seemed to follow, yet her comprehension was unclear. Nevertheless, after Duncan finished, she quickly nodded. “Oh, what should I do now?”

“Remain here, continue sitting under this ‘tree,’ just as you did when analyzing the flight paths of the external barriers. Keep connected with the mansion,” Duncan instructed, lifting his right hand to reveal a tuft of pale green flame soaked in starlight. He handed the flame to her, “Take this; it will create an additional ‘bridge’ between you and me. I’m now heading to the ‘missing’ part of the mansion to place a marker. If my predictions hold, I should be able to ‘interfere’ with Navigator Two and transfer data to your ‘system core’ through this external bridge.”

Alice simply responded with an “Oh,” and nodded eagerly. “Okay!”

As she spoke, she grasped the tuft of flame from Duncan without hesitation – a peculiar warmth spread through her palm, the ethereal flame turning palpably gentle, subtly swaying in her hand.

Holding the small flame carefully in one hand and her “drawing board” in the other, Alice turned and made her way back to the “Data Tree,” a structure woven from innumerable cables and pipes. She sat down on the platform, looking up with a beaming smile and declared, “I’m ready!”

Duncan smiled and nodded, then turned to exit the hall. He walked through the ornate door that linked the garden to the deeper parts of the mansion, moving along a lengthy corridor lined with locked rooms and filled with the hum of servers. He passed various stairways and halls, quickly reaching the deepest part of the second floor’s corridor—the “fracture point” where the escape pod detached from the main body of the ship.

The corridor’s end looked just as he remembered; the floor, ceiling, and walls appeared violently torn apart by some colossal, invisible force. Beyond the fracture point, the endlessly deep darkness of space loomed, so profound it seemed one glance could pull someone into its void.

Duncan ignored the daunting abyss, focusing instead on a particular section of the wall near the corridor’s end. There, he swiftly found what he was seeking close to the fracture.

Embedded in the wall was a display still cycling through warnings about the unauthorized release of the escape pod. Duncan approached the display, took a deep breath, and closed his eyes halfway, murmuring, “…It’s time to verify my guess… Let me ‘see’… the true appearance here.”

A faint starlight peeked through the slits of his half-closed eyes as he carefully controlled his increasingly restless “essence.” He was tapping into his power, trying to open his “other pair of eyes” without fully unleashing the singularity within him.

Gradually, Duncan opened his eyes, and a bright starburst erupted from them, resembling ancient stars relearning their orbits. Amid the expanding starlight, he beheld the other side of Alice’s Mansion.

He saw the enormous ark spaceship floating in the boundless dark chaos of space. The torn starship retained only about a third of its original structure. Standing at the end of a connecting corridor in the ship’s midsection, Duncan observed the silver-gray and silver-white alloy structures that replaced the dark-toned floors and walls of the mansion’s original corridor. Various warning lights flickered in the distance, and before him lay the scorched, molten support frame of the escape pod where it was blown open.

Duncan glanced at the broken pipes, supports, and the blasted hull of the spaceship at the end, his lips twitching slightly as he mused, “…Ray Nora

definitely didn’t leave as ‘quietly’ as she claimed. How did she manage to blow this place up without having any idea what it was?”

Of course, there was no one in the deserted spaceship corridor to answer his rhetorical question, as the only “owner” and “victim” of this place had no clue what an escape pod was. Duncan sighed and shook his head, then refocused his attention on the flickering display.

Now, he could see the full extent of this device—it was part of the external release system for the escape pod, fixed on a curved support that was severely twisted and damaged, with internal pipes exposed. Despite its battered state, it still appeared functional.

Placing his hand on the device, Duncan prepared to “read” the data with his own flame and transfer it to Alice. His plan was simple and direct.

Alice, in her current state, was oblivious to the deeper workings of her own mansion and consequently unable to detect the system malfunctions occurring within it. Although the instincts of the “Navigator Two” system remained intact, Alice’s inability to interpret these signals meant there was no response. Therefore, Duncan’s task was to establish a direct connection between Alice and the malfunctioning point of the mansion using a temporary fix—a technique he compared to using a jumper wire.

He admitted to himself that he didn’t fully understand the mechanics of the spaceship—akin to how many who repair phones might not know the detailed architecture inside the chips. The important thing was that attaching the wire effectively resolved the issue.

As he initiated this makeshift repair, the flame from his tool began to merge with the escape pod’s release system.

At that moment, Duncan’s peripheral vision caught sight of an anomaly.

A mass with a dark gray metallic sheen, resembling mud that flowed and shifted continuously, had emerged from the nearby equipment grilles and pipes without him noticing.

This eerie, mud-like substance gathered on the floor, slowly creeping towards him with a deeply unsettling low rumble. Duncan tensed, ready to react, but just as he prepared himself for action, the substance halted a short distance away as if it was observing or assessing him.

In a flash of realization, Duncan recognized it—the “Cleaners” from Alice’s Mansion, a peculiar entity designed to expel “intruding foreign bodies.”

He wondered if this entity was part of the New Hope’s maintenance system, possibly a form of “damage control” or a swarm of nanomachines.

While maintaining his interaction with the escape pod system, Duncan’s mind raced with possibilities. Just then, he observed the “nanomud” inch slightly closer without showing any signs of hostility.

Under his watchful eye, the nanomachines formed what appeared to be a tentacle-like limb, which gently tapped the curved support of the release system, seemingly attempting to show Duncan something. It then pulled a damaged cable from the support.

Duncan looked perplexed and asked, “…You mean, connect from here?”

The mud formed another limb, gesturing up and down in the air.

With slight hesitation, Duncan allowed his flame to extend to the indicated damaged cable.

The mud appeared content, vibrating its limbs before collapsing back into a liquid form and making a gurgling sound as it slowly moved towards a crack in the nearby wall.

Duncan was left speechless, “…”

He was stunned by the realization that this entity could not only communicate but also think.

As he grappled with this revelation, the mud had completely disappeared. Then, through their psychic link, Alice's voice excitedly broke through: "Captain! The drawing board lit up! The drawing board lit up! I think I figured out where the 'escape pod' is!"

…

Helena guided Vanna and Lucretia across the central bridge of the residential sector, updating them as they moved. "There are now one hundred seventy-six people here—all 'awakened' are here," she informed. The area they traversed was originally part of the broiler system. As the number of awakened individuals grew, those who initially regained consciousness in better condition naturally congregated here, transforming the location into a makeshift camp.

Vanna paused on the bridge, leaning on the railing to gaze down at the living quarters hastily arranged using the existing infrastructure of the broiler system.

After a brief pause, Helena continued, "We will soon expand into a better-conditioned living area—the dormitory next to it. It's currently occupied by our 'bewildered brethren.' We can't forcibly evict them; we must avoid conflicts as much as possible. However, as more and more awakened people begin to dominate that area, once the awakened are in the majority, we can extend our main activity area there."

Lucretia broke the silence that followed, her voice reflecting her disbelief, "…Hard to imagine, the world has actually become this…"

"Adapt as soon as possible," Helena advised softly. The Pope, in her avatar form, turned to face Vanna and Lucretia with a somber look. "The current

city-states are just this place magnified a thousand times," she explained. Then, shifting the conversation, she prompted, "As for now… it's your turn, tell me about the world's end."

Chapter 835: The Clouds

In a world blanketed by fog, wanderers roamed aimlessly outside the boiler where deep roars echoed from the harbor's fog-enshrouded facilities. The core of cold steam hummed vacantly as it merged into eerie mirages. The once-thriving sanctuary of flames had vanished, and with it, the distinction between "normal" and "abnormal" blurred into oblivion. As minds and the world itself deteriorated, sanity ironically became synonymous with madness and contamination. Those labeled insane had gathered within high walls, constructing their final stronghold, watching anxiously as the world outside succumbed to dArkness.

"We will prepare ample supplies for the Bright Star," Helena declared from a high platform atop the boiler room, addressing Vanna and Lucretia who stood beside her. "You can move to the western dock—it's one of the few external channels we currently control."

"Can this 'lighthouse' still provide supplies?" Lucretia asked the Pope in astonishment. "Do you really have that many resources?"

"Yes, we're not short on materials, which might surprise you," Helena responded with a smile. "In fact, the 'operation' of the entire world continues, including the production and transport of major supplies, even 'commercial activities' within the city-states… Every fortnight, a cargo ship loaded with supplies arrives from the border base, refueling this lighthouse and more. Those engulfed in trance handle the exchanges as usual, while we 'awakened ones' use old permits dug up from files to move some of the

materials to other storages. Likewise, we can utilize many of the facilities here."

She turned, her gaze sweeping over the vast platform outside the boiler.

"Yes, this world is still functioning, every part… operating in a trance along old trajectories, like a massive ship internally collapsing but still drifting on its original course in the ocean under inertia. Us awakeners on board are powerless to fix the ship, but at least we can 'sail' with it before it capsizes."

Vanna and Lucretia stood speechless for a moment, unsure how to respond.

The world had become unrecognizable to them.

However, Helena appeared unconcerned, simply waving her hand and continuing, "Thank you for informing me about the events at the world's end. Now those of us waiting on the Ark finally understand what's happening outside; our wait now has a purpose, no longer just a desperate struggle to survive. Is the Vanished still sailing at the world's end?"

"Yes, Captain and Alice are at the world's end, still advancing further," Vanna whispered. "They are preparing for the new world. When everything is ready… you can 'blink your eyes.'"

"Good, then I won't delay your journey any longer," Helena's avatar turned, softly exhaling. "I'll arrange the supplies, and someone will escort you two back to the dock…"

She suddenly stopped, gazing intensely into Vanna's eyes for a long moment before speaking.

"Vanna, safe travels – we'll meet again in the new world."

Vanna solemnly nodded: "Yes, Your Holiness, we'll meet again in the new world."

…

The howling wind had unknowingly ceased, leaving only the sheer, extreme “cold” on this icy plain—a cold that penetrated flesh and bone, freezing the soul. Amidst this icy wind, the Flame Bearers, who had long forgotten the warmth of “fire,” continued their journey.

The living dead trudged across the ice plain, their chest lanterns casting a faintly twinkling line deep into the ice.

Frem stood on a hastily erected platform, gazing into the distance where the imposing silhouette of the Ark silently stood far away. Its lights painted a twinkling “mountain” in the night, while lights from the lanterns flowed endlessly between that “mountain” and the ice beneath his feet, weaving back and forth tirelessly.

After the icebreaking device had become completely unusable, the Flame Bearers resorted to using the explosives they had carried on the ship to break through the next segment of ice. After the explosives were depleted, the Ark continued with its powerful drive and sturdy armor to break open another path, until finally, its power system shut down completely. Although the steam core still howled vacantly and air flowed through the pipes, the giant ship remained stuck in the ice, halted just short of its destination.

Fortunately, the distance to the final “focal point” was not far, and they were already within the influence range of the focal point. At this moment, civilization’s last “archive” was being established on this ice plain.

Footsteps echoed from the side as a veiled priestess approached the platform where Frem stood. She stopped beside him and bowed slightly. “Another eleven have ‘awakened.’ They’ve been settled in the camp and are currently undergoing psychological comforting and counseling,” she reported.

Frem nodded slightly in acknowledgment. “How are they doing?”

“Better than the last batch,” the priestess answered. “We find that continuously conveying hints and reminders to those in a ‘trance’ state is useful. When they ‘awaken,’ most of them almost immediately recognize that this is still a controlled ‘situation’ and seek help from the nearest contact person. We can share these experiences with the city-states.”

Frem nodded again, his gaze returning to the construction site of the archive.

The engineering machinery, transported from the Ark, was actively engaged on the ice plain. A cluster of buildings, crude and somewhat unattractive, began to emerge.

Compared to the majestic Ark and onboard cathedral, these buildings, resembling rough factories, lacked aesthetic appeal. Their sole design goal was to construct as sturdy a storage space as possible in the shortest time, given the unfamiliar environment.

“Does this really make sense?” A soft murmur came from beside him.

Frem turned his head to look at the priestess beside him.

“Sorry, Your Holiness, I am not wavering, I just…” the priestess shook her head, struggling for words, “I just thought about recent events—more and more people are ‘awakening’ from their ‘trance,’ many with their last memories dating back to the day we set sail. Many have asked me what has happened along the way, so many questions…”

“I understand what you’re trying to say, Delice,” Frem interrupted softly, his gaze still fixed on the construction site. “Many believe that as long as people survive, it’s as if everything is preserved because civilization is created by people, and people can recreate civilization countless times… I understand, yes, and I couldn’t agree more. As the Pope of the Flame

Bearers, I understand better than many how civilization is established and continued."

He paused, his voice still soft. "A civilization without people is meaningless, but Delice, there's also the other half of that saying—people without civilization are similarly so. Civilization isn't just the cold stones and books, not just the mute sculptures, scores, and crafts; those are merely the carriers and forms of civilization, not the abstract civilization itself. All of these points are correct, but—

"Civilization needs carriers, needs evidence.

"It's foolish to cling to 'carriers' while abandoning 'essence,' and it's equally foolish to recognize the essence but think carriers are unnecessary. Without carriers and evidence, even the most brilliant memories will erode over time, eroding before people have a chance to rebuild civilization. And even without considering this… Delice, we also need to leave some evidence, so that many years later, future generations can understand what happened to this world. The significance of artifacts and archaeology lies in this 'informing.'"

The veiled priestess, Delice, faced Frem's gaze squarely. Her once bright eyes, which had turned murky and dim days ago, now held a firm resolve.

"I understand, and I will also tell others your teachings…"

Frem nodded.

A thin "fog" had unknowingly appeared around them.

Delice looked up in surprise at the white fog fluttering around.

Since entering the ice plain, they hadn't encountered "fog" for a long time.

Though the eternal curtain's majestic fog wall was visible on the horizon, unlike other border seas, this ice plain almost never saw fog.

“The weather has changed…” She raised her hand, touching the insubstantial fog, “Is there fog on the ice plain now?”

Frem frowned, looking up at the sky, observing the flowing, drifting wisps of white, finally realizing.

“No, this isn’t fog,” he suddenly declared, his voice filled with surprise. “… this is cloud!”

“Cloud?” The priestess paused, as if recalling what “cloud” meant after a moment of thought, then her eyes widened in astonishment. “The clouds have fallen from the sky?”

“…The altitude of the clouds has lowered,” Frem spoke gravely, but he quickly realized this explanation didn’t make much difference and added, “It’s not so much that they’re ‘falling,’ it’s more like…”

He paused, and Delice had already understood his meaning. The priestess blinked, her tone tinged with unease, “The sky itself is lowering…”

Chapter 836: The Clouds Descended, and the Curtain Closes

Around the world, a distinctive atmospheric layer, infused with the essence of clouds, gradually descended. This layer resembled a vast, flowing ocean above, seamlessly merging into the sky. In some regions, it drooped toward the earth or sea, forming a misty veil, while in others, it floated several hundred to tens of meters above the inhabitants, continuing its slow, almost imperceptible descent.

Frem stood on the icy plains under the night sky, his eyes fixed on the tumultuous clouds now so close that only a thin mist separated him from them. The scene was illuminated by light piercing through the clouds, casting a mercury-like glow over everything that momentarily stole one’s breath and stirred the soul.

Beside Frem, Priestess Delice stood, both looking upward at the celestial phenomenon after a prolonged observation. Around them, many others scattered across the tundra were similarly transfixed, as if held in place by an invisible force. However, the atmosphere shifted as people began to panic, their eyes darting around, many focusing on Frem.

“Your Holiness…” Delice broke the silence, her voice hoarse, “What do we do now?”

“Continue with our tasks,” Frem replied, his voice deep and steady, resonating across the icy tundra, “Construct the archives, transport the

relics, safeguard our legacy—the world still lives; our mission is not complete."

The Pope's voice, firm and authoritative like a massive boulder, anchored everyone's restless spirits. Momentarily pausing, the Flame Bearers bowed their heads and then turned their attention from the sky back to their work on the archives.

Unnoticed, Frem exhaled softly. Despite the frail pulse of his heart, his worried gaze shifted back toward the distant drifting mists.

…

Against a stark grey-white backdrop, the immense structure of the Vanished silently floated in the "transition channel," devoid of reference points. Although it seemed stationary at the center of the channel, Duncan knew well that he and his ship were moving at speeds beyond human comprehension.

The Vanished had ventured beyond the world's edge, and Duncan had truly departed the Boundless Sea, leaving behind the sanctuary built by ancient kings. Beyond the tranquil channel lay utter chaos: the extinction of worlds had left behind a tumultuous, scorching waste known as the Ashen Sea.

As Duncan felt his connection to the Boundless Sea weakening by the day under Alice's control, he struggled to hear the voices of his two "avatars." Now, he experienced only brief daily intervals of their consciousness, with their actions severely limited.

This weakening connection stemmed from several factors: Duncan's "transformation" was intensifying, and the physical "distance" between the Vanished and the avatars was growing. As Ray Nora mentioned, other potential reasons might have involved the Ashen Sea's unique environmental conditions.

However, there was positive news. The “enhanced marks” Duncan had placed on Nina and others to maintain contact under challenging conditions were still functioning effectively. These marks, designed for a specific, straightforward purpose, remained largely unaffected by the changes, enabling continued communication with his crew.

After conducting his daily checks, Duncan wandered through the Vanished, moving through deserted corridors and silent stairways until he reached the empty deck. Alice was at the stern, steering the ship alone without the presence of her usual companions, making the ship feel as it did when Duncan first arrived—abandoned and silent, echoing his initial encounter with the Vanished.

But some things hadn’t changed—his mind was noisier than during his first visit.

From somewhere in his mind, Shirley’s unrefined voice echoed, “Hey hey, Captain, let me tell you, we snagged a bunch of great stuff from that lighthouse! That woman, Helena, was really generous. She let me raid the warehouse, and I even found some gorgeous dresses… I don’t know why someone like her would hoard pretty dresses… pity they’re too big for me, two sizes too large…”

Then Nina’s sensible and gentle voice followed, “Uncle Duncan, everything’s fine here. Nilu and I have become good friends, and I even helped her sew a little dress… You must take care of yourself on the ship, and make sure you and Alice eat on time. I left lots of biscuits and jam in the kitchen…”

Sailor’s hoarse voice chimed in, “Captain, I haven’t been slacking these past days. Miss Lucretia can testify; I’ve already started helping her crew clean the deck and hallways—I wasn’t this diligent on the White Oak…”

“Papa, don’t listen to his bluffs; he was coerced into working by Luni because he just lounges in the warehouse all day. He even tried to convince my servants to join him for a ‘big sleep.’ Luni couldn’t tolerate it anymore… This guy even had the audacity to demand a daily wage from me, claiming that working wasn’t part of his agreement when he signed on with the Bright Star!” This complaint-laden voice belonged to Lucretia.

Duncan halted on the mid-deck, listening to the cacophony of voices in his head, and finally, unable to contain himself, remarked, “Sounds like you all are having quite a lively time.”

“One Shirley is enough to turn any place into a battlefield,” Lucretia’s voice, heavy with exasperation, resonated in Duncan’s mind. “She causes chaos everywhere, even managed to coax Nilu into hiding in a bedside cabinet yesterday. I had to take apart the entire thing to get her out! How do you usually deal with this?”

“Usually, I think it’s manageable,” Duncan responded thoughtfully, “It’s very quiet on the ship, so a bit of commotion is actually quite nice—even if it might be a bit overwhelming for you.”

Lucretia let out a deep sigh, “Ah, the most overwhelming thing is still Miss Vanna’s morning workout routine… although, that might not be as surprising as Nilu’s antics.”

As he listened to his daughter’s grievances, Duncan’s expression subtly changed, reflecting on the potential excessive chaos aboard the Vanished…

Then, a moment later, Morris’s voice returned. “How are things on your end?”

“The Vanished is still in the ‘channel’,” Duncan replied, glancing outside the ship’s rail before casually adding, “Honestly, it’s hard for me to gauge from a ‘distance’ or ‘route’ perspective where exactly we are, even Alice

isn’t sure. But one thing is certain, we are nearing the coordinates given by Ray Nora. Alice can still sense that.”

“…I never thought the one who seemed the least reliable on the ship would end up doing the most crucial task,” Shirley interjected, “In the end, she’s the one who’s with you at the world’s ends…”

As Shirley’s comment hung in the air, a brief silence followed. After a few seconds, Duncan heard Shirley again, “Hey, why are you all silent! Alice isn’t as dependable as me! I’m usually so well-behaved… Nina, don’t look away!”

Duncan chose to ignore Shirley’s antics.

“How’s the situation on the Boundless Sea?”

After a brief pause, Morris responded, “Just as we reported earlier today, the clouds have descended—it’s now all covered in a thin ‘mist’ with low-hanging clouds everywhere… truly, if we didn’t understand the significance, it would indeed look like a magnificent spectacle.”

“The good news is, other than the clouds lowering, no other severe changes have occurred; at least it hasn’t affected the navigation of ships,” Vanna’s voice followed, “We’re currently heading towards Pland. Lucretia plans to take us there first; afterward, she’ll return to Wind Harbor with the Bright Star and stay there until the end.”

“We’ve also made contact with Mr. Tyrian; after reaching the central sea, a ‘Sun Sharing Fleet’ will leave Pland and head north. Miss Agatha will transfer to that ship and travel to Frost.”

“As for Sailor, we’ve arranged for him to meet Captain Lawrence in Morpheus if the city-state government is still operational. If not, the White Oak will come instead to take him to Morpheus.”

Vanna paused for a few seconds before adding softly –

“Captain, please rest assured, we will handle everything well and won’t let you down.”

Chapter 837: Shhh, Thinking

Duncan had been quietly listening to the diverse voices echoing within his mind—calm and reliable reports from Vanna and Morris, hesitant complaints from Lucretia, and occasionally, the passionate rants from Shirley and the kind advice from Nina. These voices, bridging time and space, wrapped around him like chains of warmth, anchoring him to reason and humanity, even as his two avatars within the city-state were slowly becoming ineffective.

After a while, Duncan paused his communication with Vanna and the others and walked slowly across the deck. He navigated through the stern stairs and ramps until he reached the towering stern helm.

The doll was still positioned quietly at the helm, her hands clenched tightly around the dark, heavy steering wheel. Her eyes, unfocused, stared straight ahead. Countless invisible threads stretched from her body, connecting her to the Vanished below her feet and the illusory projection of the New Hope in the sky.

Suddenly, a thin mist began to emerge from all around the deck, swirling and converging together.

Duncan noticed the eerie appearance of the mist and instinctively furrowed his brow. He then realized that the gray-white backdrop in the distance seemed to be slowly “cracking”—at the end of the uniformly textured “channel,” large patches of fog formed, and deep within this fog, there was an unmistakable sense of void.

Almost at that moment, he heard a fragmented, muffled voice say, “Jump complete…”

The Vanished experienced a subtle shake, less abrupt than its previous encounters at the border node when it had entered a kind of “medium,” causing a noticeable vibration. The channel silently shattered, and the endless, thin mist instantly filled the surroundings. The next second, Alice, who was at the helm, blinked, and the doll’s consciousness suddenly snapped back into her shell.

“Captain!” The doll turned to Duncan, her face lighting up with a joyful and proud smile. “We’ve arrived!”

Duncan nodded but was about to speak when he suddenly paused—he noticed that the edge of the Vanished was rapidly becoming “blurry”!

Not just the edge, but the entire ship was quickly blurring. Under the cover of the mist, everything within his sight seemed to suddenly lose its clear “boundaries.” The details on the deck blurred, the masts gradually faded into the fog, and even Alice in front of him seemed to merge with the mist, transforming into an ethereal form.

And the ghostly green flames enveloping the Vanished also dissipated during this process!

Alice seemed to notice something; she stood astonished in place, then slowly looked down at her hands, which were rapidly losing detail and becoming “blurry.”

“Eh?” she uttered in confusion.

But the next second, Duncan suddenly reacted.

The ghostly green flames that had enveloped the Vanished shimmered with a layer of hazy stardust. Duncan’s eyes sparkled as if filled with billions of stars, and the Vanished, teetering on the brink of information collapse,

rapidly reassembled and regained clarity in his vision. Under the stardust-infused flames, the deck and masts almost instantly reverted to their original state, and Alice's figure also stabilized in front of him.

The doll barely had time to comprehend what had just occurred; she only noticed the flames on the ship suddenly "changing color," and then the same colorful flames engulfed her as well. After a brief moment of astonishment, she raised her hand, examined it, and let out an exclamation: "Wow!"

Still feeling a residual fear, Duncan took a deep breath. For the first time, he felt a slight touch of reality about the ashen edge that Ray Nora had discovered.

This was indeed the true boundary of order, the periphery of nothingness, the "Sea of Origin" where information units remained unassigned. Here, the information had not yet been defined, and nothing from the shelter, even the Vanished emerging from subspace, could maintain a stable "data structure"—simply because there were no data structures here.

Only those who had survived the Great Annihilation and had achieved "self-stability" on the informational level could maintain themselves relatively "safe and stable" in this void.

Like the "Reverse Singularity," like the wreckage of New Hope.

Taking a deep breath to calm his emotions, Duncan reached out and gently touched Alice's hair, then looked around. Speaking of the wreckage of New Hope, where was Ray Nora?

He and his ship had already reached the location indicated by the escape pod's signal, but as he scanned the towering stern deck, he saw no physical entity amid the chaotic and empty "fog."

“Can you feel the signal from the escape pod?” Duncan asked Alice, his brow furrowed slightly, “We should have arrived at the location, right?”

“Yes, theoretically, it should be right here,” Alice replied, her attention returning from the enchanting stardust around her. She hurriedly sensed the direction of the escape pod, then scratched her head, a bit puzzled, “The signal is nearby… I sensed it just now, why can’t I see it…”

Duncan’s mouth twitched suddenly: “Could it be that we’ve bumped her away again…”

Startled by his remark, Alice keenly caught the implication: “Again?”

Duncan replied with a dismissive tone, “…You don’t need to worry about that. Let’s find Ray Nora first.”

As he spoke, Duncan slowly extended his own perception, cautiously controlling the portion of his power that belonged to the “Reverse Singularity,” all the while trying to detect any unusual aura surrounding the Vanished.

At that moment, he was preoccupied with two concerns—first, he hoped that the unfortunate Frost Queen had not been accidentally displaced by the Vanished, and second, he hoped she hadn’t been crushed beneath the massive ship.

His intention was to meet with the queen, not to inadvertently cause her harm, which would certainly make for an awkward explanation during their face-to-face meeting.

Meanwhile, Alice had come to a realization. After thinking hard for a while, the doll slapped her hand and exclaimed, “Yes… The Vanished came directly according to the escape pod’s signal, so when it landed, didn’t it directly land on the escape pod…”

Duncan sighed deeply—realizing this now did little to help the situation.

Had he known, he wouldn’t have allowed Alice to jump directly to the escape pod’s beacon; he would have set a “certain distance from the jump marker” as a safety buffer. How could he have anticipated that the positioning of the New Hope would be so precise? Previously, when the Vanished went to the Four Gods node, it hadn’t directly collided with their foreheads…

And just as he was lamenting internally, Duncan suddenly sensed something truly unexpected.

He “scanned” an entity that did not belong to the Vanished.

But the location of that entity… was on the Vanished itself.

Duncan looked up, puzzled, in the direction of his perception. After confirming what he sensed, his expression gradually turned thoughtful.

Alice noticed his focus and asked, “Ah, Captain, have you found it?”

“Let’s go over and see what’s happening,” Duncan murmured as he led Alice away from the helm. They walked through the platform and connecting stairs, following the guidance of their senses, and finally arrived at the door of the… captain’s cabin.

Alice looked up at the familiar place, her hands on her head, “This is the captain’s cabin, I don’t see anything else.”

However, Duncan continued to stare intently at the captain’s cabin door, also known as the Door of the Lost, sensing the changes here, and even… gradually understanding the changes that had occurred.

After frowning and pondering for a long time, he finally stepped forward and placed his hand on the side of the door hinge.

The twisted misalignment of the space-time structure emerged in his mind, turning into a tangible map that he could understand. He found the node of

this space-time misalignment and gently pushed.

The door swung open—from the position of the door hinge.

Alice watched the unfolding scene in bewilderment. After a long pause, she finally blurted out, “Can it open from there?!”

Duncan responded, “…Shh, I’m thinking.”

Behind the door, a layer of hazy glow seemed to encompass a “room space” that did not belong to the Vanished, enveloped in a layer of constantly trembling visual phenomena.

Unlike the typical scenario where opening the Door of the Lost would transport directly to a “bachelor apartment,” this time, what appeared before Duncan seemed to be a genuine “entrance,” one that could potentially allow entities other than himself to enter.

He first cautiously reached into the glow to test it, then turned his head to look at Alice, asking, “Do you want to come?”

Alice nodded without hesitation, “Yes!”

Duncan extended his hand toward the doll, instructing, “Follow me—hold onto my arm, and don’t let go until it’s safe.”

Alice obediently clasped Duncan’s arm, following the captain into the layer of hazy glow.

They seemed to pass through a layer of icy curtain, and after a brief moment of dizziness and sensory dislocation, the scene before them stabilized rapidly.

A lavish and spacious room materialized before Duncan and Alice, both real and tangible.

Ray Nora was sitting somewhat blankly on the large bed in the center of the room, staring bewilderedly at Duncan and Alice who had just pushed through the “door” and walked in. The Frost Queen appeared to have been greatly shocked and was a bit dazed until Duncan approached her. She suddenly snapped to attention and raised her hands, gesturing in the air.

“…Just rolled right over!” Ray Nora’s expression became increasingly frantic as she exclaimed, “Such a big ship! It just rolled right over me! Half the room was suddenly hit by a mess of stuff and shattered into pieces. It took a good while to recover, and then you pushed open the wall and walked in! Such a big hole! Can’t you use the door?”

Pushing open the wall?

Duncan was momentarily stunned, then looked back at the direction from which they had come.

He saw Ray Nora’s room door, which was properly embedded in the wall, still tightly closed, but next to the door was a large hole—that was where he and Alice had entered.

Space-time misalignment.jpg.

Alice quietly poked Duncan’s arm, “Captain, why aren’t you speaking?”

“…Shhh, I’m thinking again.”

Chapter 838: An Invitation at the End of the Century

On the very edge of the chaotic expanse, where the rules and nature of information were distorted, Duncan spent a full minute in deep contemplation before deciding to stop trying to solve the problem.

At that moment, there was a silver lining—Ray Nora had not been expelled from the Vanished, nor had she been crushed beneath the ship. Unfortunately, she had been violently rammed by the ship itself and was now slightly dazed.

This situation gave Duncan a vivid image, reminding him of a renowned global artwork back from Earth: Dog lodged in the front bumper as a car sped down the highway.

Duncan cleared his throat twice, dismissing the unsettling image, and walked a few steps with Alice. His expression was a mix of apology and concern. “Sorry, I wasn’t paying attention while we were driving the ship… Are you alright?”

Lost in thought, Alice paused before suddenly tapping Duncan on the arm. “Captain, I recall it was the Vanished that collided with the White Oak, and then I boarded your ship. Now it’s the Frost Queen’s turn—is this a pattern?”

Duncan shot her a sharp look. “’Pattern’ isn’t quite the right term here!”

At that moment, Ray Nora began to regain her composure, massaging her throbbing head as she slowly rose from the bedside. “I’m okay, just a huge shock—I didn’t anticipate such a… ‘shocking’ arrival.”

While speaking, Ray Nora’s gaze lingered on Alice, observing the girl who bore a striking resemblance to her with a mixture of curiosity and complexity. Alice met her gaze with a serious, inquisitive expression.

After a significant pause, Ray Nora smiled and extended her hand to Alice. “Hello.”

Alice responded with a beaming smile, eagerly grasping Ray Nora’s hand. “Hi there!”

“It’s incredible,” Ray Nora murmured to herself, noting the firmness of Alice’s handshake. She then turned to Duncan, “I never thought my first encounter with Alice in this dimension would be under such supernatural circumstances… though it’s hard to say if this place is the ‘real dimension.’”

With those words, she gently withdrew her hand and walked across the room, gesturing toward a wall.

Instantly, the wall disintegrated, transforming into a transparent curtain. Beyond it lay an infinite expanse of void and swirling clouds of chaos.

“I’ve been waiting here for quite some time,” Ray Nora began as she gazed into the chaotic void beyond the transparent curtain. She explained, “During this period, I attempted to navigate the edge of this dense fog but found nothing—just this endless, chaotic whiteness. Initially, I couldn’t even see the fog; I only sensed something ‘there.’ It was only after our last meeting that I started to actually see these mists, but that’s all I can do.”

“Don’t tell me you’ve tried venturing deeper into the ‘fog,’” Duncan said, his face showing a mix of curiosity and concern. “That would be incredibly

reckless.”

“Don’t worry, I’m eager to explore, but I haven’t lost my senses,” Ray Nora replied with a smile, shaking her head reassuringly. “The dangers lurking deeper are unimaginable, and even with the ‘Drifting House’ for protection, I likely wouldn’t survive a return.”

“Your caution is commendable,” Duncan responded, visibly relieved. “That’s a completely uncharted and unknown ‘primitive data sea.’ Any entity entering would be instantly reset to the same undefined state—it’s a different concept from this ‘border’ state here.”

Ray Nora nodded slightly, then redirected her curiosity to Duncan: “Now that you’re here, what do you plan to do next?”

“First, I need to validate my theories, then conduct some research and experiments to see if I can develop some ‘samples’ in this primitive data sea,” Duncan answered promptly, his determination evident. He then turned his focus back to Ray Nora with another question, “But now I’m more curious about something else… can you leave this room?”

“Leave this place?” Ray Nora paused, her eyes shifting to the door-shaped gap that had appeared when Duncan and Alice had entered the room—the softly glowing “passageway” still clearly stable.

“You mean…” she slowly realized, “to accompany you to the Vanished?”

“That’s a stable passage door, though its method of opening might seem odd now,” Duncan nodded. “It appears to support free movement, but I’m unsure if you, as an entity, can leave this room.”

“…It should be feasible,” Ray Nora frowned slightly, considering the possibility for a moment. “I’ve reached through the door before, retrieving ‘intangible things’ from the sea of ashes, and I’ve left this room to enter

your palace floating in the endless void. Although I'm tied to this 'Drifting House,' it seems there are no issues as long as I don't stray too far."

"That's reassuring," Duncan said with a smile, extending an invitation to Ray Nora, "Would you like to visit the Vanished?"

The Frost Queen responded with a smile and a slight bow: "It would be an honor."

Passing through the cool curtain once more, Duncan and Alice experienced the familiar slight dizziness and sensory misalignment as they returned to the deck of the Vanished.

Duncan turned back to confirm, and indeed, Ray Nora had successfully passed through the door—she stood in front of the "Door of the Lost," her expression still slightly puzzled.

Ray Nora widened her eyes. Despite her preparations, the actual moment of passing through that door was still unavoidably perplexing.

She now found herself on the solid deck of the Vanished, surrounded by a vast "world." Everything around her was vivid and strikingly "spacious."

She had finally stepped out of her confinement.

"I…" Ray Nora's lips moved several times, and after a lengthy pause, she finally spoke, "I actually walked out of the room…"

"Welcome to my ship. Before we explore this vast sea of ashes, let me show you around," Duncan said, smiling as he opened his arms in a welcoming gesture. "It's quite empty now, might seem a bit quiet, but it used to be very lively."

Ray Nora listened, her mind gradually adjusting to her new environment. With a faint smile, she stretched vigorously, finally free from her confinement.

“Feels good to be out,” she said softly, then turned her head to look back towards the direction she had come from.

The Door of the Lost, which had been pushed open from the hinge side, stood silently in her view.

Duncan noticed Ray Nora’s contemplative silence and casually asked, “What are you thinking about?”

“…I’m thinking…”

Duncan suddenly coughed twice. Adopting a serious and professional demeanor, he quickly explained, “I know what you’re likely thinking. This door is indeed quite magical. It can rebuild ‘passages’ in a disordered time-space relationship through different ways of opening. But you only need to know two ways to open it—pulling it open from the doorknob normally leads to my captain’s quarters, pushing it open from the hinge connects to your Drifting House.”

Ray Nora blinked, her curiosity piqued. “What’s the principle behind it’s function?”

Duncan thought for a moment before responding with a straight face, “Because it’s very magical.”

Ray Nora decided not to press further.

Duncan then stepped forward, closed the “Door of the Lost” in the usual manner, restoring its normal state before pulling its handle again, opening the door to the captain’s quarters.

He turned and made an inviting gesture towards Ray Nora.

Inside the captain’s quarters, the black wooden goat head mounted on the sea chart table heard the noise and immediately turned its neck with a

squeak and a creak. It was the first to notice the Frost Queen walking side by side with Alice.

The figure on the table visibly paused, then exclaimed in surprise: “Whoa! I guess this definitely isn’t two Miss Alices—Captain, you’ve brought an incredible guest.”

“This is my first mate,” Duncan raised his hand to introduce the talking object, “Its name is Saslokha, but you can just call it Goathead.”

He then pointed towards Ray Nora, informing Goathead: “This is the Frost Queen, probably no need for much introduction. Don’t worry about the middle principles and processes; for now, she’s on board as a guest.”

“Hello, Mr. First Mate, you can just call me Ray Nora,” Ray Nora responded politely, but then she paused, seemingly realizing something. “Wait… Saslokha? I think I’ve…”

“It’s all from when I was younger,” Goathead interrupted, suddenly acting shy and shaking its head as if reflecting on a long life. “Back then, I was still complete, had a body below my head… but now, I’m just this ship’s first mate, Captain Duncan’s most loyal first mate.”

As it spoke, Goathead stretched its neck to the side, using its chin to point towards another “Goathead” (Skull of Dreams) positioned on the other side of the sea chart table. “This one is also Saslokha, my other head, but this head has some problems, now it can’t communicate. Normally it’s just me talking to it one-sidedly—it’s a good listener, silent and patient. The captain always complains that I talk too much and tells me to shut up, but this head won’t. And let me tell you, I always feel this head actually responds when I talk to it a lot, sometimes it even moves a bit, but the captain always says that’s my delusion…”

“Quiet.”

“Okay, captain.”

Ray Nora observed this bizarre scene with a somewhat stunned expression, struggling to grasp what had just unfolded. It felt as if a wave of sound had suddenly washed over her, leaving her bewildered and speechless…

The last time she had experienced such an overwhelming sensation was just a few minutes ago when the Vanished had rolled over her…

Chapter 839: The Test

Ray Nora had embarked on an incredible journey aboard a magnificent ship, captained by a remarkable leader known as Duncan, flanked by an equally impressive first mate, an unusual dove, and a doll that strikingly resembled Ray Nora herself.

The setting was vastly different from anything the Frost Queen had imagined, yet it surpassed her expectations in every aspect.

After touring the upper deck, Duncan escorted her back to the main deck.

“The ship is vast, featuring multiple layers of cabins beneath us,” Duncan explained, his warm smile radiating comfort. “Exploring every nook and cranny could easily consume a whole day. However, we should first focus on our immediate tasks.”

Upon hearing the captain’s instructions, Ray Nora snapped out of her awe for the ship. She quickly composed herself and turned her attention to the ship’s hull, where it was encased in a gentle fog that seemed harmless.

However, this was no ordinary fog; outside the ship, the space was engulfed by a profound, indescribable void. The “fog” was merely a faint illusion created by the limited sensory capabilities of humans, barely detecting the presence of “something.”

Ray Nora’s gaze involuntarily shifted back to Duncan. Beneath his tall and formidable appearance, another being resided, the “thousand-faced starlight.” This entity was intently gazing into the distance, probing the fog for something elusive.

Duncan, also Zhou Ming, moved towards the deck's edge. His senses stretched across the ship, using it as a conduit to delicately "touch" the unseen "Sea of Ashes" outside. Within the fog, he discerned traces left by the annihilation of a world.

He soon reached out beyond the ship, his fingertips ablaze with flames colored by starlight.

At that moment, faint noises and vibrations emanated from deep within the ship, with masts and ropes creaking, their sounds tinged with a hint of unease.

"Don't worry," Duncan whispered, more to himself than anyone else, "I remain your captain."

The disturbing noises eased slightly.

Duncan's fingers then made contact with the "area" beyond the hull for the first time.

Simultaneously, a flapping noise filled the air as Ai, the dove, noisily descended from the mast and landed on Duncan's shoulder, flapping its wings vigorously and emitting sharp, peculiar cries: "Hot…hot…hot…"

The dove then jumped from Duncan's shoulder and, in either anxiety or excitement, fluttered chaotically across the deck, squawking in a manner that only Duncan could understand, leaving Ray Nora completely baffled.

"…What is this dove saying?" Ray Nora couldn't resist asking the nearby doll, though conversing with a doll resembling herself was strangely unsettling. She found no one else to turn to. "Hot… what?"

"Oh, Ai has its unique way of communicating," Alice replied nonchalantly, as if it were self-evident. "It's conveying something vital to the captain."

Surprised, Ray Nora inquired further of the doll: “…Can you understand it?”

Alice was candid: “No, I can’t.”

Silenced by this response, Ray Nora fell quiet.

Alice noticed the sudden silence beside her and curiously turned her head toward Ray Nora, known as the “Frost Queen,” and asked, “Eh? Why have you stopped talking?”

Ray Nora sighed, her thoughts seemingly drifting to the past. “…I wish I had your positive outlook back then,” she confessed. “Life used to be…very exhausting.”

“From now on, try to take things a bit easier,” Alice suggested warmly, patting Ray Nora on the arm with a smile. “Those tiring days are behind you.”

In response, Ray Nora began to sense that this seemingly naive doll might actually possess a unique kind of wisdom.

Duncan, who had overheard their conversation, continued to focus on the “world” outside the ship—the ashes that surrounded them.

Gradually withdrawing his hand, Zhou Ming opened his eyes to the fog, where ancient starlight expanded in his vision. At the focus of his gaze, he observed the unassigned basic elements of information transforming under the bath of starlight.

After some contemplation, he pointed his arms in a specific direction.

Ray Nora and Alice abruptly stopped their conversation when sounds reminiscent of wind and mountain streams emerged from that direction, their eyes widening in astonishment.

In the hazy fog, a massive, colorless, and detail-less gray mountain range began to materialize within the clouds. The mountain evolved rapidly, as if it were alive, its surface revealing gorges and gradually adopting various colors. Sounds emanated from that direction—sometimes distant, sometimes near, sometimes real, sometimes illusory.

Standing at the edge of the deck, Zhou Ming watched as information reconfigured before his eyes and was reassigned in his thoughts. He raised his hand as if strumming guitar strings, and the “mountain” that was rapidly gaining a sense of reality suddenly split in the middle, releasing a magnificent waterfall that cascaded down, forming a river. In the next moment, the river surged, vast plains emerged on either side of it, and a land more extensive than any city-state Ray Nora knew of expanded and spread in the fog. Then, the fog dissipated and condensed into clouds and a blue sky…

This creation continued to expand rapidly, eventually encompassing the ship, with the river feeding into a vast lake on which the ship floated on the mirror-smooth surface. Seconds later, “wind” was generated, causing ripples on the lake’s surface.

Ray Nora approached the edge of the deck, watching as the green land and blue sky, along with the lake and mountains, stretched to the horizon as if the entire world had been shaped right there. She inhaled the fresh air and listened to the sounds of the wind and water, a profound realization dawning within her — everything here was real and “effective,” and if someone came to this vibrant lakeshore, they could indeed survive here!

They would be able to breathe, drink the water, cultivate crops in the fertile soil, and observe the flourishing of birds and animals across the mountains and plains. Rain would fall, clouds would gather and disperse with the breeze, plants would thrive and then wilt, and life would continue its cycle.

A joyful smile almost erupted across her face at that thought.

But before the smile fully formed, Duncan—known as Zhou Ming—lowered his hands.

And just like that, everything around the ship silently collapsed and dissipated. The mountains and plains instantly reverted to a fog, all colors and contours returned to chaos, and the sounds along with the breeze that had brushed her cheeks… seemed as though they had never existed.

Ray Nora stood dazed at the scene, seemingly unable to react immediately. After a prolonged silence, she finally turned toward the captain.

“This was merely a test, a basic one at that,” Duncan approached Ray Nora, his voice deep. “It was merely to verify whether the ‘materials’ here could be reactivated—creation isn’t as straightforward as this.”

Ray Nora detected a complex tone in the captain’s voice, and her heart tightened: “So… the outcome of the test…”

“There’s good news and bad news,” Duncan exhaled slowly. “The good news is my initial assessment was correct—the information doesn’t vanish, it merely loses its original ‘definition’, and reassigning it can revive this mathematical machine.”

Ray Nora quickly asked: “And the bad news?”

“The bad news is that my other assessment was also accurate—the current conditions cannot sustain this rebooted mathematical machine, as you’ve just witnessed. Once my observation and definition are withdrawn, everything reverts to its initial state.”

“So, simply reassigning them is futile. Everything must return to ‘singularity’; I need a starting burst of energy, and a big bang… requires harsh conditions.”

Ray Nora tried to grasp the captain’s line of thought, the knowledge she had gained in that “nest” previously now resurfacing in her mind. After a moment of reflection, she tentatively responded: “…You know what it needs?”

Duncan paused, then nodded: “…Yes.”

“Can you achieve it? Is it exceedingly difficult, or outright impossible?”

This time, Duncan did not respond directly. After a long pause, he simply shook his head: “I still need to consider it carefully.”

With that, he gestured to Ray Nora and Alice.

“I need to retreat to my quarters to plan the next steps,” he sighed, turning towards the stern. “There are many vacant rooms below deck; Alice can show you where to rest.”

As Duncan walked away, Ray Nora turned to the doll beside her: “He seems deeply preoccupied—is the ‘captain’ always so… human-like?”

She had deliberated for a long time to choose the word “human-like,” cautious not to utter it in Duncan’s presence.

“Yeah,” Alice nodded casually, “Shirley said the captain can be quite human!”

Ray Nora was puzzled: “…?”

Was “human-like” used that way?

But before the Frost Queen could inquire further, Alice swiftly changed the topic: “I’ll show you to the restrooms on the ship… By the way, would you like some fish soup?”

Ray Nora was caught off guard by the abrupt shift in conversation and hesitated before replying: “Uh, no thanks.”

Alice remained enthusiastic: “The fish soup is really good! It’s a famous dish on this ship!”

“Thanks, but I… probably won’t enjoy it.”

“You don’t like fish? How about sweet pancakes? The captain loves sweet pancakes!”

Ray Nora appeared embarrassed: “…I’m currently a ghost.”

“…Oh.”

Chapter 840: Ray Nora was greatly shocked

Beneath Goathead, a faint creaking noise emanated as its neck slowly rotated on its pedestal. It watched in silence as Duncan made his way back to the captain's quarters, its gaze intently following his every move.

Upon reaching the chart table, Duncan seated himself in the high-backed chair and rested his hands on the tabletop. The sea chart before him was shrouded in mist, obscuring the details and creating the impression that even this remarkable chart had lost its guiding ability in this mysterious "sea" that had long surpassed any known boundaries.

Duncan's attention, however, was not on the obscured sea chart. Instead, he seemed to be looking through the desk and the ship's floor, reaching out towards the vast emptiness beyond the known realms.

After a while, Goathead spoke up cautiously, "I just noticed… there has been a significant change in the 'environment' surrounding the Vanished. Did you cause this?"

In contrast to his normal demeanor, Duncan remained subdued, possibly influenced by the somber atmosphere.

"I conducted some experiments," Duncan replied softly. "I tested the hypothesis that information endures and confirmed that the 'Ashen Sea' still supports the functioning of objects, at least in the brief experiments where the ripples of change manifested anew in this cooled ash."

“But it didn’t last, did it?” Goathead hesitated before adding, “I sensed it… the emergence and disappearance of the ‘ripple’ you mentioned. Although I don’t understand the principles and processes involved, I can sense that something fundamental seems to be missing behind those changes.”

“The initial driving force, a process capable of instantly resetting and fully rebooting the entire ‘mathematical machine’,” Duncan disclosed the insights he had gained from the fleeting ripple. “Simply put, short-term, localized manipulation of materials in the Ashen Sea is futile. The overall ‘entropization’ of the Ashen Sea causes all changes to revert to nothingness. Thus, if we truly want to transform the materials here into a new world, we need to reset the entire system. Integrating the preserved data from the old world during the reset process should be relatively straightforward.”

Goathead was silent for a long time, reflecting deeply. Eventually, it slowly raised its head and said, “I’m not sure what you mean by ‘entropization,’ but it seems you are still contemplating some quite radical plans. Forgive my bluntness, Captain… Miss Nina would be saddened, given your promise to her.”

Duncan remained silent, his gaze fixed intently on Goathead on the table.

“Do you consider yourself the most suitable ‘initial driving force’?” Goathead asked, undeterred by the captain’s intense scrutiny. “Resetting the entire ‘mathematical machine’ seems to require immense energy and ‘information,’ both of which you ‘yourself’ possess…”

“I am exploring an alternative,” Duncan suddenly interjected, his tone calm.

Taken aback by the interruption, Goathead’s neck emitted a series of squeaks and creaks, “…I thought you were planning on sacrificing yourself…”

“Yes, I had considered that, but Bartok reminded me before he left,” Duncan stated calmly. “He advised against using sacrifice to lay the foundations of a new world too readily. Sacrifice should always be the last and most reluctant choice, not the initial strategy. Too easy a sacrifice diminishes its significance. Besides, I promised Nina and Lucy that I would return home.”

After saying this, Duncan sighed softly.

“Of course, if there really is no other option, I am not opposed to dying, but for now… I think I should put more effort into finding a better solution.”

“Do you have an idea?” Goathead asked curiously. “Is there another way to initiate the process?”

“In theory, all I need is information and energy, and the ‘information’ part can be supplemented later through post-assignment. So, what I primarily need is energy, energy to restart the mathematical machine, to activate the ‘information’,” Duncan explained thoughtfully. “I have a vague notion for resolving this issue, but its feasibility remains uncertain…”

He paused suddenly, his gaze fixing on something invisible in the distance. After a brief moment, he resumed, “I think I need to speak with someone with whom I have an appointment.”

While speaking, he casually inquired, “What is Alice currently doing?”

Goathead hesitated briefly, checked the situation on the ship, and a subtly human expression appeared on its rigid wooden face: “…She is with the Frost Queen, preparing to engage in something quite peculiar…”

This remark from Goathead underscored the strangeness of the situation.

On the spacious mid-deck, Alice was eagerly dragging Ray Nora to demonstrate a trick she had recently mastered. The doll was visibly excited, pulling the bewildered Frost Queen onto a barrel and then pointing to her

own head, exclaiming, “I just learned this! I practiced it a lot with Luni to succeed!”

Before Ray Nora could grasp the situation, the doll embraced her own head and yanked it upward with a “pop,” tossing the head into the air.

She then adjusted her body left and right, aligning her neck joints to catch the descending head…

It was only then that Ray Nora understood what the doll was attempting to do—though she might have been better off not knowing.

To make matters worse, the doll failed to catch her head.

Her head plummeted down, landing head-first with a “thud” against her neck joint, and rolled to a stop at Ray Nora’s feet, looking up innocently and blinking: “A slight… slight miscalculation… help pick… up…”

Ray Nora’s eye twitched as she observed this debacle. The Frost Queen, who may be accustomed to overseeing the Abyss Plan and confronting rebels without flinching, appeared momentarily unsettled by the spectacle.

Duncan arrived on the deck just in time to witness this unusual scene.

He had been struck quite hard—though perhaps not as hard as Ray Nora had been.

He swiftly stepped forward, seized Alice’s head, and reattached it to her neck with a definitive “pop.” He then turned to face the still bewildered Ray Nora, his expression subtly apologetic as he explained, “Sorry, Alice sometimes thinks differently from most people…”

It seemed that only then did Ray Nora recover from her shock. She stared at Duncan blankly before finally uttering, “…This is the first time I’ve witnessed such a scene from a third-person perspective.”

Duncan: “…”

Unexpectedly, the Frost Queen added her second remark: “Frankly, it’s quite interesting.”

“I was talking with Alice when she mentioned that her neck joints tend to loosen easily,” Ray Nora elaborated, spreading her hands and appearing calmer than before, “Out of curiosity, I asked her to show me exactly what she meant. Her demonstration turned out to be more thrilling than I had anticipated…”

What could Duncan really say to that? He merely twitched the corner of his mouth, turning to adjust Alice’s head while giving Ray Nora an awkward smile.

Ray Nora, however, appeared unfazed, observing the scene with interest. It was neither simple nor normal, yet it felt extraordinarily peaceful and routine. After a moment, she smiled and remarked, “It seems she’s really happy.”

“If only she weren’t always so carefree,” Duncan sighed helplessly. “Seriously, are you really okay? That scene just now… I thought you might be traumatized…”

“I’m fine,” Ray Nora assured him, taking a deep breath. “When my head was cut off back then, I didn’t see it myself—associative things can be overcome.”

Duncan paused for a moment, realizing that the Frost Queen indeed possessed a very strong mind—and even stronger peripheral nerves.

At that moment, Alice seemed to realize something, turning her head to look at Duncan: “Captain, did you come to find me?”

“Yes,” Duncan carefully freed the last strand of hair caught in Alice’s joint, nodding, “We’ve arrived here, and there’s an appointment… it’s time to keep it.”

Alice blinked, finally recalling something, “Ah, the flaming meatball hanging at our door…”

Duncan was surprised, amazed that the doll could remember such details so accurately, and even more impressed by Alice’s refreshingly unconventional way of describing it…

Ray Nora looked on, puzzled, not understanding what the two were discussing. She couldn’t help but ask curiously, “An appointment? Where are we going next?”

“It’s an appointment for me and Alice,” Duncan smiled, “Don’t worry, we won’t leave this ship, just briefly visit another dimension, and we’ll be back soon.”

“Yes, the captain is going to wind me up!” Alice exclaimed happily, waving to Ray Nora, “You go back to your room first, I’ll come to play with you after I’m wind up!”

Ray Nora listened, even more bewildered: “Wind up?”

But the doll obviously had no intention of explaining further, pulling the captain towards the rear deck, leaving the Frost Queen bewildered with a head full of question marks.

Chapter 841: The Letter

At the beginning of his monumental journey to the world's edge, Duncan had established an agreement with the Black Sun. He had committed that once he verified the cornerstone of the emerging world at the frontier of civilization, he would honor the entity's request for inclusion in this new world. In exchange, the Black Sun promised to provide Duncan with a crucial "clue" about this unknown world.

Upon reaching the Sea of Ashes, the time had arrived for Duncan to fulfill his promise.

Inside the captain's quarters, Alice sat gracefully on the bed, facing away from Duncan as he slid the navigation key into the doll's keyhole with a slight sound of friction. After a fleeting sensation of dizziness and a sensory reset, Duncan found himself in Alice's Mansion's expansive yet somber hall.

The entrance of the mansion featured a dark door embellished with intricate designs, standing quietly at the end of the carpet. Rays of sunlight peeked through the door's crack, hinting at the shadowy figure of the Black Sun waiting beyond.

However, Duncan did not head straight to the door to meet his appointment. Instead, he explored deeper into the mansion, where he found Alice lost in thought with a drawing board in the navigation chamber before returning the doll to the hall and approaching the door.

For reasons he could not fully explain, Duncan wished to share all future experiences in this “land of all endings” with the doll.

Alice displayed a constant and palpable happiness, showing no fear of the Black Sun she was eager to encounter, whom she whimsically called the “flaming meatball.”

When Duncan finally approached the mansion’s door, he easily pushed open the slightly ajar entrance. Despite its appearance of weight, the door moved effortlessly, creaking on its hinges as it swung open. A brilliant yet bearable, artificial sunlight burst into view.

Encased in a luminous sphere of flames, a pale, distorted mass of flesh slowly expanded and writhed. A large, half-open eye seemed to cast a drowsy glance: “Ah, Flame Usurper, you have arrived… are you here to fulfill our agreement?”

Duncan confronted the bright stare: “I have now reached the end of all things and verified the cornerstone of the new world. I am here as we agreed.”

The Black Sun stirred; its fiery shell gently rose, and a deep, resonant tremor emanated from its numerous tentacles and bulges: “Ah, it seems you have made significant progress… So about my initial request, a place in the new world…”

“Yes,” Duncan quickly interjected, cutting off the other’s inquiry.

The prompt response seemed to surprise the Black Sun; its movements and the trembling of its flesh paused momentarily before it spoke hesitantly again: “You are certain…”

Duncan responded earnestly, “Indeed, the new world is expansive enough to provide a place for you—and your ‘home’ as you remember it in your

memories—but that is contingent upon the new world being completed as planned."

"You aren't concerned that I might become a 'dangerous element' in the new world?" the Black Sun inquired. "My kind and I have been exiled from this sanctuary for ten thousand years, and now you are bringing me and the other tribes back to the new world. Don't you see this as a potential risk?"

Duncan calmly reiterated, "As I've mentioned, the new world is vast, immensely so—your civilization is not everlasting, and the 'hidden dangers' you worry about will be diluted by the enormous spatial expanse and the passage of time. In such a prolonged safety period, your civilization will lack the opportunity to interact with others. Regarding you…"

He paused, a subtle smile playing in his eyes.

"Being one of the 'ancient kings' who established the foundations of the sanctuary, you are intimately familiar with the original blueprint of the Boundless Sea and all its systemic flaws. Given your profound understanding of the 'sanctuary,' I suspect… this world actually lacks the ability to 'exile' you. Or rather—if you had wished to return to the Boundless Sea, you would have done so on the day the kingdom of Crete launched Vision 001 into the sky."

He looked up, observing the immense eye at the core of the writhing sun.

"In the history of constructing this sanctuary, there were no records of conflict among the ancient kings; all was settled through negotiations—you chose exile voluntarily, though the actions of your descendants and survivors spiraled out of control."

The Black Sun fell silent for a moment before slowly speaking, "The creation of the sanctuary was 'extreme.' Back then, we couldn't afford even a slight waste of resources or time. The Long Night had already failed

twice, and we were compelled to succeed on our third attempt… no one had a choice."

"Thank you for your prudence back then. Let's forgo unnecessary tests and assumptions between us. I have made my plans—now it's time for you to fulfill your promise," Duncan's tone became stern, his expression serious, "You mentioned you have 'evidence' concerning the new world. What exactly is it?"

The Black Sun remained silent but slowly stretched out its slender tentacles from the edge of the fiery eyeball. A limb suddenly extended, holding something at the end which it precisely delivered to Duncan.

Alice, who had been deep in thought beside him, started and leaned in curiously, "What is this?"

"A letter," the Black Sun responded with a tremulous voice that filled the void. The small tentacle expanded, revealing an object to Duncan.

It appeared as a silver-gray cube, about ten centimeters on each side, adorned with intricate patterns. Though its design was intriguing, it seemed less significant than what Duncan had initially anticipated.

Duncan stared at the small metal cube with a puzzled expression, noticing its slightly translucent, blurry surface. It was evident that since only the projection of the Black Sun had visited this place, the cube he observed was also merely a projection.

The actual cube resided with the Black Sun, somewhere beyond the confines of the real dimension.

Duncan suddenly frowned as he discerned specific patterns on the cube's surface.

Seemingly anticipating Duncan's reaction, the Black Sun thoughtfully moved the cube's projection closer to him, slowly rotating it to display each

side.

On the first surface, Duncan observed a human silhouette standing on a map filled with numerous lines and reference points.

The second surface revealed a series of circles, arranged in size from smallest to largest.

On the third, he saw intersecting lines where each junction appeared to illustrate a mathematical principle.

However, the fourth surface was covered in child-like scribbles, their naive strokes starkly contrasting with the precise and meaningful designs on the other sides.

The fifth surface was dotted with numerous random depressions that seemed to represent a “star chart” of constellations or a similar celestial system.

His attention then shifted to the sixth surface.

It was adorned with distorted symbols!

These symbols initially seemed to represent various types of writing, but they had been twisted under some unknown influence into shapes that were utterly unrecognizable. Duncan felt as if these contorted symbols were alive; as he stared, each line seemed to tremble and rearrange itself, obscuring their true forms.

Duncan instinctively reached out to touch the cube, but his fingers passed right through the illusion.

“Its ‘physical’ form is not present, but I can describe its condition to you.” The Black Sun’s voice resonated in his ears, “It is a metal ingot, as hard as steel yet surprisingly light, hollow inside and hiding a potent energy source which I cannot examine without compromising its integrity. It seems to

possess a powerful ‘mechanism’ that emits information outward, though this mechanism is also concealed within.”

“Furthermore, it originally held more information, including the ‘text’ you noticed that is unreadable.”

“Initially, it even produced sounds, but only as chaotic noise; it consistently emitted some sort of ‘signal,’ but even I cannot decipher what it is, and now, its emission process has largely ceased. I cannot determine if this is due to a malfunction or if the energy has depleted… however, it likely isn’t related to energy depletion, as the energy reaction inside it remains robust.”

Listening to the Black Sun’s detailed explanation, Duncan stayed silent for a considerable time, merely observing the continuously rotating cube. Finally, after a lengthy pause, he broke the silence: “So, this is a letter, a letter from the ‘new world’ to the ‘old world’—is that what you are suggesting?”

“Yes.”

“But how can we confirm this?” Duncan inquired, unable to hide his skepticism. “How do you know it’s not just another relic from the Great Annihilation, like other twisted fragments?”

“It originates from a place where, theoretically, no ‘fragments’ should exist,” the Black Sun replied calmly.

Duncan immediately frowned in thought: “A place where no fragments should exist?”

“…The World’s Creation.”

A heavy silence fell over the scene.

Duncan’s eyes widened in astonishment as he gazed at the projection of the cube, noting its effort to convey various messages, including the illegible

text.

This was indeed a letter.

But who had sent this letter?

Chapter 842: A Thoughtful Alternative

Duncan gazed intently at the cube suspended by the tendrils of the Black Sun, noting the messages on its surface that seemed to have struggled significantly to reach him.

He reflected on the journey of this small metallic cube—how it had been transmitted to this world, to this era, through mysterious methods and processes unknown to them.

The cube acted as a letter, a missive from the new world to the old, yet all evidence that could prove this had been obliterated by some enigmatic force. Its creators had likely tried countless methods to let the cube “declare its origin,” but these efforts had evidently failed. However, these failures did not make the attempts pointless.

Its mere presence served as a testament, and though this interpretation might just be a bold assumption by the Black Sun, at that moment, Duncan was prepared to accept this assumption as the sole truth.

In the ensuing silence, the deep, resonant tremors of the Black Sun finally broke the quiet: “The cube’s manufacturing process and function surpass my understanding—beyond any knowledge system that has existed in any city-state, beyond any technology known to me before the Great Annihilation.”

“On the other hand, from a ‘purposeful’ perspective, I see no rationale for why anyone would create and position this cube within the World’s

Creation—especially since even the ancient kings lacked the capability to send objects into the World's Creation. Thus, the only plausible explanation I can think of is that this cube originates from a world and an era beyond my understanding."

"I am acquainted with all the history of this shelter—the only aspect unknown to me is the future, the future concerning 'the new world.'"

The edges of the Black Sun slowly expanded its radiant yet deceptive corona, its tendrils ablaze, stretching across a sea of flames before gradually curling inward.

One tendril, reaching far to the entrance of the mansion, stayed firmly in front of Duncan as if it were presenting a treasure, delicately supporting the small, unassuming metallic cube.

"Flame Usurper, this letter has no designated recipient. Someone or some group in the new world tried every possible means to send it to this era, yet they couldn't ensure the cube would directly reach any particular individual… but I sense it's intended for you."

Duncan struggled to express his feelings at that moment. He examined the symbols and patterns on the cube's surface, and although the text was blurred and disordered, he managed to decipher part of the message the "letter" conveyed—the human form (self), order, mathematics, a child's doodles, and stars.

"They exist in a logical and stable world… they can gaze upon the stars," Duncan murmured, almost to himself, "They live securely, and…"

"And, they have reached an advanced stage of development," the Black Sun added slowly, "The manufacturing techniques used for this cube are exceptional, as are the methods used to send it 'here,' none of which are recorded in any known 'blueprints.'"

For a while, Duncan remained silent, standing beside Alice who blinked in curiosity. Miss Doll watched the distant Black Sun and then the nearby cube, and though she did not understand the complex concepts of “manufacturing technology,” “development stages,” and “blueprints,” she at least realized that the cube was a significant item sent by someone important, which eventually prompted her to break the silence: “Captain, who could have sent this ‘letter’?”

The first thought that came to Duncan’s mind was that someone, or perhaps a group, from the new world was responsible. However, as he was about to speak, he suddenly paused, his resolve wavering. After a prolonged period of deep thought, Duncan hesitantly reached out towards the projection-like cube—a collection of stardust-like flames dancing at his fingertips.

As the flame approached, the Black Sun’s tendril instinctively shrank back, but eventually, it cautiously reached out once more, its voice simultaneously murmuring, “This is merely its projection, the actual body of the cube is not present here.”

“I understand, but I want to see if I can ‘hear’ or ‘see’ anything,” Duncan replied. “Projection or not, it makes no difference to me if there’s an informational mapping relationship.”

The Black Sun remained silent, merely lifting the projection of the cube slightly.

Duncan’s fingertip flame seamlessly merged into the projection, much like rain blending into water.

He stayed silent, intently absorbing the information conveyed by the flame—he felt the flame slowly dissolving into a void and, even with his “singularity” eyes, saw nothing deep within the flame.

No echoes, no “memories,” all profound information carried by the cube seemed to have been erased during its journey through the World’s Creation.

Duncan waited patiently until the last trace of the flame had completely disappeared into the depths of the projection, with nothing responding to him, leaving only a void deep within the cube.

Alice, who had been watching with bated breath next to him, dared not make a sound, fearful of disturbing him. Only after seeing Duncan sigh softly did she approach cautiously and inquire, “Did you see anything?”

“Nothing,” Duncan replied softly, shaking his head. “I fear it’s all been wiped out during the ‘transmission’ process.”

A look of disappointment crossed Alice’s face as she paused and then said, “…Oh.”

Duncan felt the sting of disappointment as well, but he said no more, simply waving his hand and turning his attention away from the metallic cube.

Yet, just as he shifted his gaze, as if a barely noticeable breeze had passed, a projection-like flicker flashed across his mind—in that nearly hallucinatory moment, he heard a voice as if emanating directly from his memories:

“…I will try everything to see you again… I will definitely leave something…”

Duncan swiftly turned back, his eyes intently fixed on the small cube.

The ephemeral voice was so fleeting and elusive that he could not be certain it was truly related to the cube, unable to determine if it was merely a “memory” that had surfaced spontaneously in his mind. The voice did not resurface, making everything seem like an auditory illusion.

But seconds later, a slight smile formed on Duncan’s face.

In his mind, there appeared the image of an elderly Cretan, hunched over in a tattered white robe, walking backlit against the light, waving goodbye, and stepping resolutely toward the endless night at the world's end in search of a flicker of light that was never meant to illuminate the old world with hardly any guidance.

Cretan had succeeded.

He had sent a message of safety from the new world.

…And perhaps, it was not merely a message of "safety."

This realization caused Duncan to slowly furrow his brows in thought, his expression shifting. Beside him, Alice sharply noticed the captain's change in demeanor and couldn't help but feel anxious, hesitating for a long time before finally daring to tug on Duncan's sleeve: "Captain?"

Duncan looked up, his face set in a serious expression. He casually patted Miss Doll's hair and gazed up at the distant Black Sun. "You just said this cube 'came' from the World's Creation?" he asked.

"Yes," the Black Sun immediately replied, its voice echoing as if from deep within itself. "This cube 'surfaced' from the depths of the World's Creation, a fact I can completely confirm."

"It sounds like you are quite familiar with the World's Creation and have been paying attention to it for some time," Duncan said, his expression growing more serious. "The other 'ancient kings' don't seem to know as much about it as you do."

"As you say," the huge and terrifying eye of the Black Sun met Duncan's gaze with a calm demeanor, no longer hiding its knowledge. "I know many things related to the World's Creation, just as I know the entire Boundless Sea… Remember what I mentioned at the beginning? Over the long years, I have always been 'overlooking' this world…"

Hearing this, Duncan's expression subtly shifted, then he suddenly realized something significant. "Wait, are you saying… your actual body is in the World's Creation?!"

"No, I am on its 'backside,'" the Black Sun calmly clarified. "No one can stay inside the World's Creation, not even the so-called 'ancient kings.' It is a place that can devour and tear everything apart, the Great Annihilation itself—but setting that aside, the World's Creation itself… is an impregnable 'barrier.'"

"It is enough to completely isolate the entire Boundless Sea and those harmful, dangerous exiles, keeping the toxic, erosive 'influences' that are harmful to the shelter blocked on the other side of the barrier—in the 'backside' of the World's Creation, is the cold land of exile, where I have been for ten thousand years, right above everyone's heads."

The… backside of the World's Creation!

Duncan's heart pounded wildly. A fact he had previously overlooked now stood clearly before him—the World's Creation actually had a "backside," and on that unimaginable "backside," the Black Sun, considered one of the oldest, most dangerous "ancient gods" feared by the entire world, was actually always suspended above the heads of all beings?!

After absorbing the shock, Duncan suddenly understood something else—

Why did the cube that "passed through" the World's Creation and was sent to this era end up in the hands of the Black Sun? Because in this world, the closest to the World's Creation was this ancient god who had been "exiled" ten thousand years ago!

"Flame Usurper," the voice of the Black Sun came then, interrupting Duncan's train of thought, "Why are you suddenly interested in the World's Creation?"

Duncan quickly collected his scattered thoughts, briefly organizing his emotions, then looked up seriously at the ancient “deity.”

“I have a rather bold plan… it might sound a bit crazy.”

“Oh?” the Black Sun voiced its curiosity, “Can you tell me? Is it related to the World’s Creation?”

Duncan thought for a moment, then nodded earnestly. “Simply put, I plan to detonate it.”

The Black Sun fell silent immediately.

After what seemed like an eternity, the twisted and indescribable “ancient god” suddenly emitted a series of strange tremors and gurgling sounds from within, then the chaotic sounds reformed into a rational syllable—

“…Ah?”

Chapter 843: The Guiding Light

Duncan had come to the realization that his plan might indeed verge on insanity—even the Black Sun seemed to require a moment to process his last declaration…

However, Duncan was sincere. Following the Black Sun's contemplative "Ah," Duncan's expression became even more grave. He restated firmly, "I intend to detonate the 'World's Creation'—when I use 'detonate,' I mean it in a figurative sense. I plan to unlock its power, specifically the aspects that were not fully released during the Great Annihilation."

After a while, the Black Sun finally regained its composure, and its deep, resonant voice, now tinged with a hint of static, inquired, "…When did you conceive this plan?"

"Before I arrived here to meet you," Duncan replied with a calm demeanor, "though at that time, my direction was only vaguely outlined, and the concept wasn't fully formed."

He paused, then added, "I have always possessed a sort of… 'intuition,' likely stemming from the 'knowledge' left behind by the civilization that created me. There are numerous mechanisms I do not fully understand, yet my instincts guide my actions and suggest the correct path forward. Motivated by this intuition, I believe that the 'World's Creation' can aid me in tackling a major challenge I face—the problem of the initial driving force."

“It wasn’t until I met you here and saw the ‘letter’ you brought that I confirmed the validity of this direction, or rather… this letter seems to act as a reminder, pointing me toward the correct path.”

Upon realizing that Duncan’s proposal was not a product of madness but a thought-out, calculated strategy, the turmoil on The Black Sun’s surface eased slightly, and it adopted a serious tone: “What do you mean by ‘the problem of the initial driving force’?”

“Fundamentally, it’s akin to the ‘Big Bang,’ the event that initiated our universe,” Duncan explained. “This is a metaphorical description. Picture it as a simultaneous explosion of information, matter, and energy. If we view the entire universe as a vast, complex mathematical device, then the initial burst of this device is that ‘explosion’ where everything began.”

“In the outer regions of order, I conducted preliminary experiments that verified the hypothesis of indestructible information, and demonstrated that ‘assigning’ values in a state of chaotic information could indeed reshape reality. Yet, I also faced a challenge: this ‘mathematical device’ of the universe maintains ‘integrity,’ where all its informational parameters must perfectly interlock. I cannot reconstruct the universe piece by piece, step by step—although I might have an endlessly long time to prepare, once the process begins, all tasks must be performed simultaneously.”

“Therefore, I require such a massive explosion, in an infinitely brief yet infinitely extensive ‘instant,’ to achieve the synchronous assignment and ‘activation’ of all information. If this is not accomplished, the new universe will disintegrate and gradually dissolve into the void—much like the current Boundless Sea.”

“And this requires an immense amount of energy, an extraordinarily vast amount… comparable even to that of a Great Annihilation.”

Duncan looked up solemnly at the massive, pallid eye surrounded by flesh and fire: “You see, my plan is quite rational and meticulously thought out…”

As the tentacles encircling the Black Sun trembled, the voice emitted a tone of growing concern, “I’m starting to feel a bit scared when you mention the term rational. I do, however, see the necessity of this plan. Indeed, such a vast amount of energy can only be sourced from the ‘World’s Creation.’ But how do we ensure that this process unfolds as you envision? How can we take control of the ‘World’s Creation’? How do we initiate it, guide it, and prevent it from spiraling out of control?”

The ancient deity bombarded Duncan with a flurry of questions, revealing deep seated concerns about the feasibility of Duncan’s plan. These worries were justified.

Positioned perilously close to the ‘World’s Creation,’ this entity understood the nature and terror of the rift more profoundly than anyone else in this world. Having observed the solidified Great Annihilation in the sky for millennia, it struggled to reconcile that catastrophic force with the possibility of a ‘new world.’

Yet Duncan, undisturbed by the Black Sun’s skepticism, had clearly pondered these issues extensively. He collected his thoughts and began calmly, “Everything is information.”

The Black Sun maintained its silence, attentively awaiting Duncan’s further explanation.

“The ‘World’s Creation’ operates on the same principle,” Duncan continued.

A faint pulsation of flames from the Black Sun suggested it was piecing together Duncan’s theory.

“After encountering the chaotic state known as the ‘information sea,’ I truly grasped the concept that ‘everything is information,’” Duncan confidently asserted, ensuring that The Black Sun was following his logic. “The ‘World’s Creation’ is the crystallized form of the ‘Great Annihilation’ itself. Yet, the Great Annihilation is also a manifestation of information. From the most basic logical perspective, the ‘World’s Creation’ is indistinguishable from the myriad things of this world.”

“As long as it is governed by ‘information,’ nothing is truly ‘out of control.’ It exists, thus it can be controlled. If it were uncontrollable, then even its ‘loss of control’ would be a controllable type, unless the principle of ‘everything is information’ fails to apply,” Duncan elucidated.”

“You seem very confident, and resolute,” The Black Sun remarked, its tentacles extending as it spoke with a deep, soothing tremor.

Duncan responded not with words but with a gentle nod of affirmation.

He held a steadfast belief: nothing could hinder the ‘World’s Creation’ from ushering in the dawn of a new world—not even the ‘World’s Creation’ itself.

“And there’s another factor that bolsters my confidence,” Duncan added abruptly.

“You mean… the appearance of that cube?” The Black Sun quickly interjected.

“Exactly,” Duncan affirmed with another subtle nod. “It traversed the rift of the ‘World’s Creation’ to reach ‘this side.’ A letter, no matter how meticulously crafted or perfectly safeguarded, that it can cross the divide between the old world and the new world to arrive here is nearly miraculous. Thus, its ‘delivery window’ must have been meticulously

chosen, likely situated at the point where the two worlds are most intimately connected…”

Duncan’s voice trailed off as his gaze drifted into the distance, piercing through the dazzling yet deceptive corona of the Black Sun, peering into a much farther realm of time and space.

In the collapsed remnants of the old world, where all knowledge converged at an “end point,” a new world burst into existence through a monumental explosion at a “starting point.”

This convergence and explosion, relative yet originating, resembled the two ends of an hourglass. At their intersection—a point that served as both an end and a beginning—lay the “singularity,” also the site of the ‘World’s Creation.’

From a distant future, a letter traveled through the only “aperture” to the opposite end of the hourglass. This letter was a message of homecoming and a beacon for the night’s navigation.

“I will come for you,” Duncan declared slowly, his gaze shifting from the horizon to focus intently on the Black Sun. “I will fulfill the promise to consume you, reserve a place for you in the new world, and then—it will be done.”

The corona of the Black Sun pulsed slowly, and from its layered flesh emerged a gentle, deep tremor: “I will light a lighthouse for you in the night sky; you must navigate towards the brightest direction.”

“Okay, see you then.”

“See you then.”

…

The night stretched on endlessly, with fog enveloping the city-state and dense clouds hanging so low they seemed almost touchable. A piercing cold pervaded the world, and although the gas lamps along the road still glowed brightly, the flames within the lampshades appeared frozen, emitting no heat.

Wrapped tightly in her coat, Heidi wasn't entirely sure why she needed such heavy clothing. Yet, an innate instinct urged her to "keep warm," even though she could barely remember what "cold" felt like.

She moved swiftly through the lamp-lit streets, showing her pass at the sheriff's post as she went, her steps quickening towards home.

Along the way, Heidi noticed more pedestrians than usual—some heading to factories, others out shopping. It was a stark contrast to the early days of this prolonged night, indicating that the citizens were gradually adapting to the darkness.

Yet, the city remained unnervingly quiet compared to the days when "everything was as usual."

Heidi ignored the other pedestrians weaving through the mist and kept her gaze down, rushing forward. Occasionally, she heard chaotic sounds from nearby streets—shouts of conflict or screams of terror. At times, she even glimpsed armed church guards clashing with frantic pedestrians in the fog, but she quickly averted her eyes and dismissed these disturbances.

Passing a street lamp, Heidi caught sight of a flyer on the lamp post from the corner of her eye. The flyer, bearing simple yet ominous messages —"Waves, death, the temperature of fire—if you see and understand these words, please immediately seek shelter in XX district or XX district. Do not panic, stay calm, people are still protecting you"—was printed with crooked, barely legible symbols.

She had noticed similar graffiti around her home recently.

Yet, it seemed unimportant.

Turning her head away, Heidi walked through the cold fog, continuing her journey home.

Chapter 844: Returning Home

Heidi experienced a wave of dizziness accompanied by a slight discomfort as she approached the final intersection on her way home. Stopping in confusion, she looked back over the path she had just traversed.

The street was enshrouded in a light mist, with low clouds masking the rooftops and dim streetlights casting an eerie glow. Shadows shifted ambiguously within the fog, occasionally producing faint, unsettling noises. Despite this, the scene appeared typical.

Heidi frowned as she noticed some text scribbled on a nearby wall. The crudely drawn symbols were difficult to discern and strained her eyes.

A robust woman standing in a nearby doorway seemed to notice Heidi's puzzled pause in the middle of the street. She addressed Heidi with a look of concern, "Good evening, do you need help?"

"…No," Heidi hesitated before responding, "I'm fine, just a bit dizzy."

"Do take care of yourself. Dizziness is no trivial matter," the woman replied, her smile warm. "If you're feeling unwell, you're welcome to come in for some hot tea."

Heidi appreciated the offer and smiled but politely declined, "Thank you for your kindness, but I feel much better now."

"Is that so? It seems a bit of fresh air really does help. It's a pleasant day today…"

After nodding and expressing her gratitude, Heidi turned away and then noticed a man in a blue coat emerging from the fog. He walked briskly, carrying a heavy parcel, his eyes filled with panic as if fleeing from some unseen terror within the fog. He looked around anxiously, cautious not to make any sudden movements, as if fearing to disturb something hidden in the mist.

Driven by instinct, Heidi approached the anxious man. “Hello, sir, are you in trouble? I’m a psychiatrist…”

The man in the blue coat, surprised, stopped and stared at Heidi. He opened his mouth as if to speak, then, sensing something unsettling about her, tensed up and waved his hand dismissively before turning and disappearing into the mist without a word.

Confused, Heidi frowned and glanced down at herself, wondering what might have caused such a reaction from the stranger.

The dizziness and unease returned with greater intensity.

A heightened sense of alertness overtook Heidi, her dormant spiritual senses awakening. Although the streets seemed normal, she now sensed an underlying threat and chill.

Something was clearly amiss, evident right before her eyes, yet she had overlooked it—the discordant elements around her…

Heidi cautiously moved to the roadside, observing her surroundings while silently invoking the name of Lahem. A sharp golden spike silently appeared in her hand.

However, she was still unsure of the “enemy” for which this golden spike was intended—was there truly an enemy present?

The pendant on her chest warmed slightly, as if reminding her of something important.

Once again, her attention was drawn to the so-called “graffiti” on the wall. The wavy lines shook and shifted, forming readable phrases: “Waves, death, the warmth of fire…”

Heidi stood frozen, engulfed in shock.

The cries of reason and memory surged through her mind like relentless waves, lost yet as persistent as death itself. She began to comprehend the profound changes that had engulfed the world and felt a deep panic rising within her. However, her extensive mental training allowed her to regain her composure more quickly than most, prompting her to survey her environment urgently.

Dark red shadows, reminiscent of flesh, crept across the night, covering walls and rooftops. The heavy clouds softened the eerie glow of the World’s Creation into strange, trembling shadows that seemed to slither and float across the city’s skyline, animating it unnaturally. On the mist-soaked street, shambling figures emitted deep murmurs and soft whimpers.

A man dressed in a gray coat wandered by, clutching a decaying, dubious substance which he consumed while muttering to himself.

An abandoned bicycle moved slowly down the street, its deteriorated wheels and chain squeaking. A twisting shadow, roughly the size of a human head, sat on the seat.

From a nearby building, a monstrous limb adorned with hundreds of blinking eyes stretched into the mist. This grotesque arm twisted around, its numerous eyes scanning the chilly night, and from it emerged a voice, eerily human:

“Good evening… It’s a nice day today…”

Heidi shuddered as a cold chill pierced through her heart and lungs.

Memories flooded back—vivid images of street graffiti and engravings she had often noticed, the unsettling discord that had always unnerved her, and the figure of a man dressed in a blue coat, who had appeared rushed and fearful.

Suddenly, she remembered that she had left her mother at home!

Taking a deep breath, Heidi spun around and dashed back along the fog-enshrouded street as fast as her legs would carry her—

Amid the fog, a startled gasp echoed, and voices weakly called out her name. The dark red shadows along the roadside trembled and gathered together. Gunshots rang out from a nearby street, sparked by some panic-driven commotion, while a mechanical spider walker, adorned with numerous eyes and mouths, stumbled forward from the opposite direction, its pressure pipes bursting open and releasing a strange, monotonous tune.

Yet Heidi seemed oblivious to these disturbances; she blocked out all distractions and sprinted straight down the street—through the fog, eventually glimpsing the lights of her home.

Grasping her skirt, she ran awkwardly for the last few meters, pausing just before she reached the front door. She hesitated, transferred the sharp “golden spike” to her left hand, and calmed her breath before cautiously taking out her key, unlocking the door, and turning the knob.

The door swung open to reveal the cold, bright light of the living room. Inside, everything looked normal, although writhing shadows still lingered in the corners, offering a stark contrast to the turmoil outside.

Her mother sat by the fireplace at the far end of the room, deeply engrossed in a newspaper that had been delivered at some unknown time.

Upon hearing the door, the elderly woman looked up with a gentle smile and said, “Heidi, you’re back—was the visit to the clinic successful?”

Heidi’s mother appeared unchanged, her usual self, much to Heidi’s relief who had been worried that unwanted visitors might be lurking in the room.

With a quiet sigh of relief, Heidi put away the golden spike she had been clutching and walked calmly toward the fireplace. “There’s no time to explain, Mother, you must come with me now. This neighborhood is no longer safe—there’s something sinister lurking outside…”

Mid-sentence, Heidi stopped speaking abruptly.

Her mother’s face remained serene, her gentle smile unchanging, showing no sign of surprise or doubt. After a short pause, the older woman nodded affirmatively, then stood and walked across the room to the staircase by the fireplace.

From beneath the stairs, she retrieved two suitcases.

“Everything necessary is present. The shelter is well-equipped with basic amenities, and the supplies remain abundant— Governor Dante always ensured that. Your ‘medical box’ has been packed and is waiting on the table in your room. Please, fetch it yourself; they’ll be needing those supplies at the shelter. And don’t forget your revolver, take several boxes of bullets with you—try to avoid using them, but if necessary, aiming for those fleshy, crawling creatures one bullet at a time continues to be effective.”

As she detailed these preparations, she walked back to the fireplace, stretched slightly to reach the old rifle that hung from a brass hook, and took it down.

Click-click, she skillfully manipulated the rifle’s mechanism, loaded bullets into the chamber, and practiced ejecting and reloading them with ease.

“I’ll stick with this one; it’s the same rifle your father and I used on our excursions. This old companion has always been reliable—one shot, one cultist.”

Heidi watched, utterly astonished, and slowly came to a realization. Incredulously, she addressed her mother, “Mother, do you mean to say… you’ve been prepared all this time?”

“I was ready the moment they posted flyers on the telephone poles. After that, it was just a matter of waiting for you to ‘wake up,’” the old woman explained, looking intently at Heidi. “Thankfully, I didn’t have to wait too long.”

Overwhelmed and speechless, Heidi remained silent for a long while until her mother’s urging snapped her back to reality. She quickly ascended the stairs to her room where she found the small suitcase her mother had packed for her, along with several cardboard boxes on the table.

Upon opening the boxes, she discovered shiny, golden bullets, each engraved with the sacred words of Lahem, the god of wisdom: “Let knowledge enter the mind.”

Heidi gazed at the golden bullets, gathered her resolve, secreted some in her clothing, and meticulously packed the remainder into the medical box.

After completing her preparations, she dashed down the stairs.

“Mother, I’m ready, we should—” Suddenly, Heidi halted on the staircase.

The front door stood open, and a familiar figure was framed in the doorway. Dressed in an old but neatly maintained woolen coat, sporting a monocle, and puffing on a pipe.

Her father had returned home.

Chapter 845: The Final Voyage Plan

Heidi had just finished bringing all the additional luggage into the living room when she approached the dining table and stared blankly at Morris, who was sitting opposite her. It had been a considerable time since she last saw her father. Although they managed occasional contacts, even those infrequent communications had dwindled to nothing long ago. Her father's sudden return home seemed almost surreal to her.

Morris was seated at the dining table, leisurely consuming freshly fried sausages and bread. He chewed each bite thoroughly and for a long time. After a while, he raised his eyes to meet those of his wife next to him and his daughter across from him, a smile spreading across his face. "It's been a long time since I've had home-cooked food," he remarked.

"There's more if you're still hungry, but we need to leave after this meal," his wife replied with a nostalgic smile, reminding him of days gone by when they would plan a stroll in the park after lunch. "We need to report to the nearest shelter—it's becoming increasingly unsafe in our neighborhood, what with those confused people… they are becoming less and less human-like."

"They have lost their self-awareness, and the world is gradually forgetting what 'human' looks like, resulting in their current state," Morris explained calmly. "The keystones and anchors set by the gods are failing rapidly, and

those who are not awakened will continue to deviate further from ‘normal’… yet in their own ‘feeling’, nothing has ever changed.”

A look of sorrow crossed Heidi’s face. “Is there no hope?”

“Don’t worry about them, Heidi,” her father replied, shaking his head with a reassuring smile. “It’s all temporary; things will get better. The captain is figuring things out—my early return to the city-state is also part of his grand plan.”

Heidi hesitated for a moment before speaking, her voice filled with a mix of hesitation and curiosity. “It seems like you’ve experienced a lot outside. Has everyone else returned? Is Vanna back?”

“Yes, Vanna is back too, along with the other crew members,” Morris nodded slowly. “Vanna has gone to the cathedral first and will head to City Hall afterward to settle things there; she will contact you once she’s done. Nina and Shirley are back home too; we have scheduled times and methods of contact, and Sailor and Agatha… they all have their own arrangements and missions.”

A hint of curiosity appeared on Heidi’s face. “Can you tell me about your journey?”

“Of course—there isn’t much time left in the world, but still enough for a grand tale,” Morris replied.

Meanwhile, in the fog that enveloped the entire city, two girls ran through the streets of the lower district. They passed suspicious dark red clumps piled on the road, weaving between buildings that blinked with countless eyes and walls that pulsated like a heart, avoiding the aimless, unselfconscious shadows that roamed the streets. The low, chaotic whispers and occasional loud noises echoed through the fog, encircling them like uninvited guests.

“This is even worse than what the female pope described!” Shirley exclaimed, a chilling atmosphere enveloping her. To embolden herself, she transformed into her terrifying demonic form, carefully stepping over the pulsating heaps on the ground with her twelve long skeletal limbs. “She only said the city is full of people who had lost themselves… but she never mentioned this kind of ‘loss of self’!”

“The situation likely changed while they were out at sea in that lighthouse.” While following Shirley, Nina couldn’t help but glance up at her friend, now transformed into a terrifying figure. “But then again, do you really need to be scared? You look more frightening than that shadow we encountered earlier,” she remarked.

Shirley quickly responded with a grin, “What’s frightening? I consider this look quite amazing, not scary at all!” She then propped herself up, surveying their surroundings thoughtfully. “Moreover, there’s a silver lining to this situation—I can freely roam around the city in this guise. It seems as though they don’t even notice me. And even if an ‘awake’ person does spot me, they’ll probably dismiss it as just another distortion and won’t bother chasing me down to shoot me…”

“You should still be cautious,” Nina warned. “What if there’s another priest like Miss Vanna patrolling the city? If she sees a shadow demon like you, she might just come at you with a sword…”

“Then you’ll just have to douse him with some sunshine,” Shirley joked, tapping Nina’s shoulder with one of her skeletal limbs. “Let him know why there are still two such bright and beautiful girls roaming the city at the end of the world…”

Nina was hesitant to engage further with her friend, whose thought processes were uniquely her own.

Their conversation was abruptly interrupted by the sound of a bell ringing through the fog. They looked towards the source of the noise and saw a steam bus with a bright yellow shell. The bus, rather peculiarly, sported several pairs of hands and feet, using them to crawl through the foggy street, while white steam puffed from its rear. It stopped near them at a station, and its middle section suddenly tore open, revealing a mouth full of sharp teeth.

“Wanna ride? Going to the museum!” the steam bus shouted to Shirley and Nina. “The curfew is lifted, and there’s a dazzling exhibition of paintings and textiles!”

Nina watched the scene in disbelief, while Shirley, after a moment of surprise, energetically waved off the offer. “No thanks! I have too many legs to get on!”

The bus replied cheerily, “Alright, alright, see you! I’m off to the next stop!” The “door” then snapped shut, and with a puff of steam, the bus raised its multitude of limbs and quickly scuttled away, vanishing down the street.

Shirley and Nina exchanged glances.

Suddenly, Dog’s silhouette emerged from the shadow between them, grumbling, “…The shadowy abyss of demons might be more normal than this place now.”

Nina remained silent, simply turning towards what she remembered as the direction of home.

Ignoring the eerie shadows and sounds that surrounded them, they eventually spotted the familiar little shop in the lower district. Among the buildings now enveloped in various sinister shadows and heaps, and almost transformed into some kind of “living entity,” the little antique shop still

maintained its original appearance—a comforting safe haven, its glass windows still emanating a warm, bright light.

Nina hurried forward, pushing open the already unlocked door. The doorbell rang crisply, echoing the familiarity of her memories.

“Uncle Duncan! Shirley and I are home!” she shouted into the stillness of the antique shop.

However, her call was met with silence.

“Uncle Duncan, we’re home!” Nina called out once more.

This time, a voice responded, though Nina briefly struggled to discern whether it originated from within herself or somewhere in the shop: “I’m behind the counter.”

Nina hesitated, her gaze instinctively drifting towards the counter next to the staircase.

There, she spotted a gaunt, hunched figure seemingly blended into the shadows, sitting silently behind the old, stained wooden counter.

Shirley, now back in her human form, walked alongside Nina into the shop, passing shelves that appeared untouched and dusty for several days, and made her way to the counter.

“Uncle Duncan…” Nina approached cautiously, noticing Uncle Duncan behind the counter slightly shift his eyes, yet remaining otherwise still, which filled her with concern, “Are you alright?”

“I have already severed most connections with this avatar,” Duncan’s voice resonated in Nina’s mind, “but I have retained just enough of my vision to see you and Shirley arrive home safely—did anything happen on the way?”

Nina, her expression complex, eventually let a warm smile spread across her face.

“Nothing,” she replied cheerfully, standing directly in front of the counter so that Uncle Duncan, distant as he was, could see her clearly, “A lot has changed in the city, but there was no danger. Mr. Morris has also made it home safely, and everyone else is fine. Shirley and I just walked here from the shopping street; many people there have already sought refuge in shelters.”

“That’s good to hear. I can only see a very limited area from here, and I’ve been curious about the outside.”

“How are things on your end?” Shirley leaned in, unable to contain her curiosity, “Did you and Alice find what you were looking for?”

“We found it, and now we’re preparing to depart to our final destination.”

“The last stop?” Nina and Shirley asked simultaneously.

“Yes,” Duncan responded slowly, “Soon, you will see the Vanished again—it will then become the most prominent light in the sky.”

Outside, the hull of the ship was enveloped by a uniform gray-white background. The Vanished vibrated slightly, then settled into a profound stillness as the ship embarked on its final journey.

Duncan stood at the stern of the ship, at the helm, with Alice beside him clutching the wheel, steering their course.

“We’ll first return to the border, but we won’t enter the Boundless Sea—the Vanished will ‘ascend’ at the Eternal Veil, and we’ll traverse the entire world from a very high place until we reach the World’s Creation,” Duncan explained, lifting his gaze as if looking through the gray-white corridor of their jump, peering at the end of time and everything beyond. “And then, that ‘moment’ will arrive.”

“Ascend? World’s Creation?” Nina’s voice, filled with astonishment, echoed in his heart, “Is that… possible?”

Then came Shirley’s exclamation: “The Vanished can still fly?”

Duncan smiled, his mouth curving into a knowing smile. “It’s possible—the Sea of Clouds is also a sea.”

Chapter 846: The Sunlit Path

Vanna stood atop the highest tower of the Storm Cathedral, her eyes scanning the horizon through a vast window. She surveyed the intricate rooftops of the church, the soft glow of lights nestled in the clouds, the slightly changed skyline of the city buildings, and the expansive stretch of the great sea in the distance.

Near the tower's spiraling staircase, steam-powered pipes emitted a soft hiss as a copper incense burner dangled from a valve on the pipe, releasing wisps of fragrant smoke. Beside her, the elderly Archbishop Valentine stood silently, his pale eyes, clouded from halted blood circulation, focused on the distant horizon along with Vanna.

Breaking the silence, Vanna whispered, "I often stood here at dusk, watching every corner of Pland. The hiss of the steam pipes and the scent of the incense always brought peace."

"It feels as if those days were not long ago," Archbishop Valentine murmured in a low tone.

"Indeed, they seem almost recent," Vanna agreed with a slight nod. "Those nights were filled with turmoil, darkness brought threats upon the people—from shadowy cultists to their summoned beasts. I was filled with determination, ready to confront any danger to our city-state."

The old archbishop remained silent, his gaze drifting toward the church garden. In the misty night, distant roars and eerie sounds echoed, suggesting the presence of a massive creature hidden in the fog.

“Granny Tereni has started her feast again,” Valentine eventually spoke, his voice slow. “Every evening at this hour, she consumes herself, only to regenerate from the earth twenty-four hours later. Nearby, twelve nuns and twelve priests remain close to Granny Tereni, entering the small abbey by the garden at specific times—just as you used to during your daily walks.”

Vanna let out a faint sigh, her voice barely audible, “Will they venture beyond the church grounds?”

“I have ordered the garden sealed, although it’s not truly necessary,” Valentine explained. “Granny Tereni never leaves the garden, even when ‘alive.’ And the nuns and priests pose no threat—there are far more dangerous shadows lurking in the city.”

“My sword feels out of place now,” Vanna said with regret.

“We still need your strength if wanderers try to scale the shelter’s high walls,” Valentine countered, shaking his head. “Disorder can erupt at any time, anywhere in the city—sometimes when people suddenly ‘awake’ in their homes, other times when blind wanderers breach our security zones. We’ve formed a new Night Watch to patrol the streets, but there are always gaps they can’t fill. Your leadership as the inquisitor would be invaluable to them.”

He paused, then continued, “You may need to adjust to some of your former comrades. Several in the Night Watch have undergone… ‘changes,’ appearing less human. But in these times, possessing rationality and humanity is a rarity.”

“I don’t mind,” Vanna chuckled, shifting her arm slightly, “After all, it’s better than dealing with the ‘human factor’ on the Vanished, right? I’m ready to return to this work—you can make the arrangements.”

“That’s good to hear,” Valentine replied, smiling and nodding in approval. “I’ll notify the Night Watch during the next shift change to share this good news. Would you like to rest in your room for a bit? It’s still in excellent shape, and someone has been maintaining it.”

“Okay,” Vanna agreed, then paused, a hint of concern in her voice. “Is there anything I should be cautious about?”

“Don’t worry about the murmuring from your vanity table; it’s nothing coherent. And try not to gaze out the window for too long—it tends to grow eyes. That’s all you need to be aware of.”

“…Honestly, the situation is quite… ‘mild,’” she remarked with a note of sarcasm.

Valentine gave a helpless shrug, but before he could continue, a sudden burst of light erupted from nowhere, cutting him off.

Both turned their eyes upward, startled, trying to locate the source of the light.

The clouds above glowed with a cold, pale light, a brilliance emanating from the World’s Creation—a phenomenon caused by the lowering clouds, revealing a “scar” that spanned the entire sky, now mostly hidden behind the clouds, only occasionally visible through the brightest, thinnest gaps.

Suddenly, between the clouds, a different glow emerged.

It wasn’t the usual cold, pale light, but a faint orange-yellow hue, blending with the light from the World’s Creation, briefly reminiscent of the long-lost… sunlight.

Vanna looked upward, searching for the origin of the World’s Creation. Through a gap in the lowering clouds, she spotted the vast “scar,” and to her surprise, the sun-like orange-yellow light was emanating from the edge of the World’s Creation.

It seemed as though a strong light source was bursting forth from “behind” the pale fissure, obscured by the cracks in the sky, allowing only a little residual light to diffuse from the edges of the cracks, thus faintly illuminating the sky.

Valentine, making the same connection, wore an expression of stunned confusion on his face, staring blankly at the sky. “What is that…”

Vanna remained silent, and just then, the orange-yellow light diffusing from behind the World’s Creation gradually dimmed and completely extinguished.

A moment later, the orange-yellow light flared up again, spreading across the sky. The invisible, powerful light source flickered on and off like a beacon in the night sky. This spectacle was visible to the entire world. Even the other dimensions could witness this scene.

At the world’s edge, at the “border node” where gods slumber, the dim, false sunlight once chased away the fog, shining over the Leviathan Queen’s palace, on the server matrix of Navigator Two, on the Ashen Isle of the Eternal Flame, and on the tombs of Bartok.

Deep in the abyssal sea, where the uncontrollably proliferating Navigator One slowly writhed at the ocean’s bottom, a vast swarm of nanomachines nearly filled every inch beneath the shattered lands. Among countless uncontrollable tentacles, the dim sunlight suddenly dispelled the darkness, illuminating the dark red core of Navigator One.

In the distant northern ice fields of the Boundless Sea, ice sculptures stood silently next to a massive archives building, the bearers frozen on the ice field, the tallest among them still maintaining a posture of looking southward before being frozen.

The faint and flickering “sunlight,” though obscured and diluted by the barrier known as the World’s Creation, still managed to cast a gleaming sheen over the frozen visages, deeply imprinting each rigid gaze.

This sunlight was toxic, lethal even for the creatures of the Boundless Sea; to them, bathing in this light was akin to drowning in the murmurs of subspace.

However, thanks to the mitigating effects of the World’s Creation, the lethal impact of this sunlight on the terrestrial world was significantly reduced. Although a trace of its toxic nature remained, it was largely negligible.

Moreover, this world was already profoundly distorted and warped. In the face of widespread disintegration, the menace posed by the Black Sun’s radiance was hardly more threatening than the ongoing collapse of the world itself.

Thus, the exiled sun began to shine unimpeded for the first time in ages. Long after those who had once cherished its light had faded into history, it now blazed fiercely amid the Great Annihilation.

The sunlight streamed through the transition channel, carving a luminous and distinct path against the stark gray-white backdrop.

Duncan sensed a subtle vibration beneath his feet; Alice was fine-tuning the transition mechanism, adjusting their trajectory based on the navigation signal emitted by the Black Sun.

Duncan narrowed his eyes, focusing on the light at the channel’s end—here, free from the obstruction of the World’s Creation, the sunlight spanned both time and space and appeared almost blinding.

“I will be your beacon in the night sky; you must steer towards the brightest light…”

The architects of a Dyson sphere, while not as technologically advanced as the “New Hope,” clearly knew how to assert their presence in the cosmos, capable of emitting a signal strong enough to guide starships.

“I see the light; we are heading towards you. This should shorten the journey of the Vanished,” Duncan communicated to the sunlight, aware that the Black Sun could hear him through this method, “How are you faring now?”

“The intense heat, it feels like I am simmering in flames—it’s painful, yet somehow satisfying,” replied the voice of the Black Sun, trembling within the beams, “This is the first time in ten thousand years that I’ve truly blazed; I thought I couldn’t bear it, but… it’s a good pain.”

“In the new world, you can exist peacefully with your own light without suffering from self-inflicted burns,” Duncan responded with a soft smile, “There will be a provision for such harmony.”

“…Is that really possible?”

“Yes, this is a unique, tailored opportunity for a new beginning,” Duncan explained calmly, “You could even request additional features—like altering your own sunlight to a shade of pink.”

“Ha, no need for that, but if it’s feasible, I do have another request…”

“What might that be?”

“Could you arrange a few more planets for me? Gas or rocky, either type would suffice. Observing the evolution of life on various planets could be quite fascinating.”

“Consider it noted—your wish will be granted after Alice gets her flat bottom pan.”

“That’s indeed a great honor.”

Chapter 847, Depth 3: Nightfall

In the days that followed, all who traveled the Boundless Sea witnessed the ominous radiance of the Black Sun—a misleading illumination that expanded and enveloped the entire world. As the last lighthouse on these waters, it cast its light across every nook and cranny of the sanctuary, providing continuous illumination for an unending sequence of days and nights.

Speculation about the source of this unusual “radiance” varied among the populace. Some theorized it was an indicator of the world’s ongoing decay, while others interpreted it as a sign of a transformation within the World’s Creation itself. Eternal optimists viewed it as a sign heralding the return of the sun, while ultimate pessimists saw it as a precursor to the end of everything. For many, however, this strange sunlight was merely an event to be ignored.

Creatures that had lost their self-awareness roamed aimlessly through the city, shrouded in mist and dim light. They ferociously devoured what they could vaguely “recognize” as food, their deep growls filling the air. At the same time, the city-states buzzed with a background noise of whispers emanating from their depths.

Over the ocean, immense, shifting shadows moved toward the coastline of the city-state. These were fleets of spectral ships, arisen from forgotten eras. Their crews—ghostly sailors and pirates—landed under the cover of night, melding with the shadows amid the howling winds, and their whereabouts

remained a mystery once they departed. However, each dock and pathway seemed haunted by the soft echoes of sea shanties and distant calls.

At night, the city's structures appeared to come alive, their original shapes obscured by the fog. Roofs seemed to grow eyes, chimneys twisted and stretched, windows developed sharp, fang-like features, and each doorway emitted loud, unnerving noises that contributed to the loudest cacophony the city had ever experienced.

In this disturbing reality, the awakened and frightened citizens constructed towering walls deep within the city. They communicated through the sewers and the remaining urban rail systems. In refuges like the city hall and churches, they maintained a semblance of order.

The inhabitants took turns sleeping, ensuring that vigilant eyes were always on the lookout in these last bastions, guarding against the transformation of walls and rooftops into animate, fleshy obstructions.

In addition, Night Watchers tirelessly patrolled the city, searching for the last survivors in completely distorted and ruined districts, protecting them from other dehumanized creatures eager to consume and obliterate their existence.

A vital directive had been issued from a distant northern city-state and had spread globally through various city-state alliances. Its message was stark and straightforward: Survive. Survive at all costs. Prevent as many as possible from falling before the arrival of the new dawn.

Although the usual processes of death were suspended, those overwhelmed by the night and madness still disappeared from this world, reduced to mere remnants within these refuges, unable to welcome the anticipated "dawn"—the final defenders of this world fought desperately to avoid this fate.

Within the high walls, those who were protected engaged in hopeful and cautious conversations about this “dawn.”

Talks of a new world emerging from the prolonged darkness filled the air.

Initially, no one knew how the news of this dawn had spread, or whether it was a deliberate act by the protectors. It might have been just a distant, elusive hope, but in this night of universal downfall, it was crucial to hold onto the hope that continued to thrive.

Lawrence stood atop a restored section of the ancient city wall that bordered the western district of Morpheus, silently gazing into the horizon.

This part of the city wall, recently refurbished and reinforced, now served as a formidable barrier protecting the frontier city-state. The massive wall stretched from the port to the steam hub factory, encircling nearly all of the city’s survivors.

Outside these massive walls, the few remaining survivors had taken refuge in two churches and nearby apartment buildings. The Night Watchers were diligently working to connect the underground networks of several shelters, aiming to include everyone.

During the night, a terrifying mix of roars and mechanical firing sounds from steam walkers erupted, intertwined with light flashes that pierced the dense fog before silence returned. After a considerable pause, a signal flare shot up in that direction, bursting into a persistent glow against the night sky.

The dim “sunlight” from behind the World’s Creation mingled with the light from the flare.

“It appears there are no survivors left in that direction, just the monsters that the city itself has spawned,” Martha’s voice emerged from a small mirror

attached to Lawrence’s chest. “It’s getting late; we’re unlikely to encounter any new ‘awakened ones’ in those long-abandoned districts.” ŖάN**OB**ĘṢ

“Morpheus is not a large city. Our search operation here will soon conclude, and in the coming days, our main task will be ensuring safety within these walls,” Lawrence nodded thoughtfully. “However, in other city-states, the search for survivors will probably persist until the very end. In those sprawling, maze-like old districts, there’s always someone still clinging to hope, waiting to be rescued…”

The “sunlight” behind the World’s Creation dimmed briefly, then surged again, illuminating the entire sky.

“Who would have thought that the last to illuminate this sky would be the ‘Black Sun,’” Martha whispered. “Just a year ago, such talk would have been dismissed as madness, not even uttered by devotees of the sun.”

“But now, no one besides us even recalls what the ‘Black Sun’ is,” Lawrence sighed, shaking his head. “All the fear and reverence once associated with it have been relegated to forgotten history.”

He looked up at the dim yellow light spreading across the sky, where the forgotten “Black Sun” still shimmered faintly behind the World’s Creation, yet its light was no longer needed by any creature in this world.

It now merely served to guide the last remaining ship still navigating these dark times.

Footsteps approached from behind. Lawrence turned from the contemplation of the sky to see a gaunt, disheveled figure in an ill-fitting sailor’s uniform emerge from the mist and ascend the city wall towards him.

“Captain, I have returned to make my report,” Sailor said, adjusting the hem of his uniform and forcing a grotesque, unnerving smile.

Lawrence examined Sailor and winced slightly: “…Could you refrain from smiling like that whenever you greet me? It’s quite unsettling.”

Sailor responded by stretching his smile even wider: “Given my appearance, I’m considered quite handsome by today’s standards in the city-states.”

Lawrence spat aside and refrained from further teasing the grim figure, instead stepping forward to clap Sailor on the shoulder. “So, how was your time aboard the Vanished?”

Sailor paused for a moment, his face marked by deep lines that gradually relaxed as he reflected, “It was a good experience.”

“That’s good to hear,” Lawrence replied with a warm smile, shaking his head in amusement. “Now that your remarkable assignment outside is complete…” He gestured broadly with open arms, “Welcome back to the White Oak.”

Sailor returned the smile, spreading his arms wide in response, “Happy to be back.”

Quickly sidestepping, Lawrence joked, “I was just saying—no need for an actual hug. Go freshen up, your scent of rotten flesh is quite potent.”

…

“Mr. Morris has taken his family to the safe haven, and he has also joined the city wall guard squad… It seems when the head of the guard saw an elderly man volunteering, he initially rejected him, but then, Mr. Morris impressed everyone there with his capabilities by beating every youngster that dared to challenge him…”

“Miss Vanna has taken up a position at the cathedral—she’s now in charge of the watchmen stationed there. It’s known that they have several out-of-control priests detained within the cathedral walls, keeping her quite busy

every day, but she seems genuinely content… She mentioned this to you as well? Yes, she's pleased to be making a difference back in the city-state…"

"Did Sailor and Miss Agatha arrive safely at their destinations? That's relieving… I heard that the ships heading north are becoming scarce, and with the deteriorating conditions in the Cold Sea, I had some concerns… It's fortunate they arrived safely, as that was likely the last fleet to depart."

"How is Miss Lucretia? Sampling the local dishes at Wind Harbor? Oh, really?… That sounds just like something a witch would do…"

In the background, Nina's voice was a cheerful hum, while Duncan sat on the edge of the deck of the Vanished, a gentle smile on his face as he listened to her distant chatter.

"Do you and Shirley have any plans?" he inquired abruptly.

There was a brief pause before Nina responded, "…Shirley and I have decided to remain at the antique shop."

"You're not considering taking refuge at the cathedral? It might be safer there."

"No, we don't have other family, and we feel secure enough. Taking refuge doesn't really align with our needs – now Dog and Shirley take turns patrolling the shop while I ensure it remains a beacon of light and warmth. Our little shop has essentially become a small 'refuge' on this street. Sometimes Night Watchers drop by for a break, and they all serve under Miss Vanna… Oh, they even call this place 'the most reliable night safe house in the city-state'…"

Nina's tone was lively, tinged with pride, clearly content with their setup. Duncan listened, his slight worry fading.

It appears that the two young women have creatively transformed the quaint antique shop into a vibrant and essential part of the community.

As Nina continued her easygoing banter, Duncan’s gaze was drawn to the changing light and shadows at the end of the transition channel.

The clouds stretched across the horizon, visible through the channel, their outlines highlighted by the diffuse ‘sunlight’, sketching the silhouette of the eternal curtain.

Finally, Duncan slowly rose to his feet and said, “Nina.”

The chattering girl paused immediately: “Hmm?”

“Get ready to look up—”

Chapter 848: Depth 2, Annihilation

The warp transit concluded its journey – the extensive voyage through the remote frontier had ended, and the Vanished had once again entered the world of fog and water.

However, this arrival marked merely a brief pause in a much larger expedition. Duncan's true objective lay not in returning to the Boundless Sea but in reaching the farthest extremity of this world, a place that hung suspended in the sky, locked in perpetual coldness.

The ship began to emit gentle vibrations as it exited warp transit. The illusion of the New Hope rapidly vanished into the sky, while countless unseen threads withdrew back into the puppet's exterior. Almost immediately, the thick fog characteristic of the frontier waters enveloped the ship from all sides, welcoming it warmly. The Vanished glided through the sea, moving silently over the calm, mirror-like water as the ship gradually stabilized.

Alice blinked, her eyes quickly regaining their brightness. She looked up at Duncan, who was standing nearby, and flashed him a quick smile. "Captain! We're back!"

"Yes, we are back in the Boundless Sea. I'll take over the helm now," Duncan replied with a smile, nodding at the puppet before heading towards the shadowy helm. "Feel free to rest or just watch if you prefer."

"Okay, I'm not tired. I'll watch!" Alice responded enthusiastically. She dragged a large wooden barrel to a corner of the bridge, sat on it with her

chin resting on her hands, and watched Duncan navigate.

Duncan glanced back at Alice with a smile of resignation, then took hold of the dark helm.

Green ethereal flames ignited between his fingers, spreading across the helm and lighting up the deck and masts. The translucent ethereal sails filled with an invisible wind. The Vanished shone brightly, reminiscent of the day Duncan first took control of the helm, a vivid memory that remained with him.

Duncan then closed his eyes. His focus wasn’t on the Boundless Sea or the eternal curtain; instead, in his fading awareness, he perceived a slowly pulsating, cold, and artificial sunlight that traced a luminous path through the darkness, leading far ahead.

He then heard a deep rumble from within the Vanished, the ropes quivering in the air, the cabin creaking. These layered sounds merged into a continuous chorus of encouragement from the ship. Amid this chorus, he heard the strange, discordant voice of Goathead.

It sang a peculiar chant Duncan had never heard before, with complex tones and strange pronunciations that seemed as if they had traversed vast expanses of time and space, sung initially to appease ancient gods, yet hardly pleasing to the ear.

With his eyes closed, however, Duncan “saw” something through the strange, off-key humming.

He envisioned bright sunlight and majestic landscapes, a gigantic tree rooting deeply into the earth, and the figure of a creator slowly emerging from a valley as if wandering in dreams.

Primitive beings, newly sentient, gathered around the great tree, adorning their creator’s resting place with colorful stones and furs. They joyfully

played rudimentary musical instruments, singing songs that celebrated the breeze and sunlight at dawn and dusk.

Now, after such a lengthy passage of time, their creator recalled this melody.

As the Vanished resumed its slow acceleration, Goathead's discordant humming morphed into the final melody of their journey. The massive ghost ship seemed to dissolve further into ethereal fire, taking on an even more convincing guise of illusion than before.

The flames climbed higher, engulfing the ship and erasing its entire history —every foundation it had laid across dimensions, every shadow it had cast —obliterating its very "existence" within their small sanctuary. The flames, suffused with pale purple starlight, transformed the Vanished into a massive, almost indistinguishable spectral form amidst the fire.

This spectral form was weightless; it floated upward through the cloud cover of this world, tracing a path illuminated by the deceptive glow of distant sunlight, and began to pick up speed as it ascended into the sky.

Zhou Ming clutched the helm, feeling the vividness of this world for the first time, acutely aware of his own existence and that of the Vanished. He felt an integral part of this fading, dimming, slowly cooling world.

He was also among the myriad displaced souls of this realm.

With his eyes firmly shut, Zhou Ming refrained from "observing" too much, to prevent the Boundless Sea from instantaneously collapsing. However, his "sensation" had already initiated the final destruction of this world.

Now, the underlying data of the sanctuary was laid bare to him, triggering the final disaster recovery uploads into the singularity database. As this ultimate "upload" progressed, the "reset" procedures at the outer barriers also commenced.

…

Nina and Shirley watched in awe.

They had reached the second floor of the antique shop, having placed Uncle Duncan’s lifeless body by the window. Though he was no longer alive, Nina kept him seated beside her, gazing out together.

The girls looked towards the southeast.

A brilliant light emanated from that direction, advancing slowly yet profoundly towards the World’s Creation.

The resplendent light, a mix of green and pale purple, bathed half the sky, ushering in a dawn-like “daylight” at the end of the long night.

“Wow…” Shirley stretched her neck, letting out an exaggerated gasp. She then tugged at Dog’s neck chain, exclaiming excitedly, “Dog, look at that! Over there! The captain is really flying! He’s heading towards the World’s Creation! It’s starting, it’s starting!” ℞

“I see, I see, stop pulling the chain,” Dog barked, gripping the chain tightly, “Find a stable spot to brace yourself. The final moment is upon us. You’ve been wondering every day when it would start, and it’s now…”

“I… I’m a bit nervous…” Shirley admitted, pressing against the wall with Dog’s chain but quickly moving back to the window, “What will happen? Will it hurt? Or will it just be over in an instant? Will there be a bright light?”

“How should I know, I…” Dog started to respond, but cut himself off.

The flames, now infused with starlight, raged through every fissure of its being, erupting and soaring from within.

Shirley blinked, raising her arms as she watched flames ignite on her own body, and through the shadows cast by the flames, she saw Nina also

gradually enveloped by fire.

“Uncle Duncan experiences the world through our perspective,” Nina realized. Her tone was calm and gentle as she assured her companion, “Don’t be scared.”

“I’m not scared, but what should I do?” Shirley responded, her voice betraying her fear as she looked to Nina for guidance. “Should I just keep my eyes wide open and look around?”

“Seeing the world through our eyes is really just a metaphor,” Nina began to clarify, but paused as she caught the naive and confused look on her friend’s face. Choosing not to continue her explanation, Nina gave a resigned smile, “Alright, just keep your eyes wide open and look around. Uncle Duncan will handle everything else.”

“Oh… Oh!” Shirley quickly agreed, promptly widening her eyes and trying her best to peer into the distance.

Meanwhile, Nina noticed something supernatural on the horizon, beyond the cloud-covered skyline, a breathtaking spectacle unfolded that was unlike anything seen in the physical realm before—it seemed as if a majestic curtain was drawing across the sky.

Stars began to emerge, and the expansive ocean known as the Boundless Sea began to silently implode, starting from its outermost regions, illuminated by the starlight.

First to be affected were the frontier maritime outposts—lighthouses, mobile ports established by the Church of the Four Gods, and their patrolling fleets, always vigilant near the eternal curtain.

Next, remote islands disappeared, the ones once visited by explorers who left behind numerous tales.

Soon, the frontier maritime city-states followed suit…

Lucretia stood on the top deck of the Bright Star, moored at Wind Harbor. She clung to Rabbi's arm and steadied the small puppet, Nilu, on her shoulder, while the clockwork puppet Luni stood faithfully behind her.

Together, they solemnly observed the stars ascend from the edge of the world, advancing toward them like a grand curtain spanning heaven and earth.

The stars first reached a platform on the distant ocean, previously a facility for studying a "glowing object," now deserted and irrecoverable by the city-state, left as a lone monument amidst the sea.

Without any process of disintegration, no sound, no flash, the platform seamlessly merged with the stars, vanishing without a trace. Behind the starlight, only sheer emptiness remained.

Nilu clung tightly to Lucretia's head, her small frame trembling: "Mistress, I'm a bit scared…"

"Don't be afraid, Nilu," Lucretia reassured her, softly stroking the puppet's back. "The next time you open your eyes, we'll be at our new home."

The small puppet nodded earnestly in response.

"Mistress…" Luni's voice sounded from behind. Lucretia turned to see the clockwork puppet's slightly anxious expression.

"Are you also scared?"

"A little."

Lucretia offered a comforting smile: "Then close your eyes, and when you open them again, it will be as if you've merely blinked."

Luni hesitated briefly, then obediently closed her eyes.

As the last light flickered at the corner of her vision, she saw the silhouette of her mistress silently merging into the starlight.

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//Lucretia·??? ==>A.. …%¥ transferred to new data*& amp ;*%¥ save completed.

Chapter 849: Depth 1, Into Silence

The observation signal from Lucretia had disappeared, and at that exact moment, all information related to Wind Harbor was quickly transferred just before a complete system reset occurred.

Zhou Ming remained calm as he adjusted to the changes happening within the shelter. He sensed the slow disintegration of its boundaries, the gradual crumbling of the Boundless Sea, and the cities among the curtain of stars fading away into nothingness. He was overwhelmed by a cacophony of voices—thousands expressing confusion, fear, desperation, and hope. It was as if tens of thousands of minds were speaking to him simultaneously, only to fall silent all at once, repeating this cycle over and over.

Zhou Ming felt detached from this cyclic disturbance. As the Reverse Singularity began to activate, he dedicated nearly all his focus to maintaining the stability and control of the process. After an indeterminate amount of time, he finally had a moment to observe his surroundings.

With his eyes closed, he “saw” Alice seated nearby. She was intently observing, seemingly detached from everything happening outside the Vanished.

He also “saw” the Vanished itself, hovering above a sea of clouds, appearing like a blazing, pristine illusion. Much of the ship had been engulfed by a fierce inferno, leaving only the core where he stood at the helm and some parts of the stern’s structure intact. Beyond these remnants was a light mist trailing a brilliant tail of flames.

Periodically, the humming of Goathead reached him; this remarkable ancient relic floated deep within the light mist, continuing its final burn.

Eventually, Zhou Ming heard footsteps approaching.

The “Door of the Lost” at the stern swung open, and Ray Nora stepped through. Known as the Frost Queen, she silently gazed at the distant sea of clouds, watching as the world faded into the starlight. After a brief pause, she walked towards the helm. Ascending the stairs bathed in starlight, she joined Zhou Ming at the ship’s control.

“I thought you had left,” Zhou Ming remarked with a slight smile. “The bonds of the Vanished are gone. Your ‘Drifting House’ could leave at any time.”

“It could indeed leave, but where would it go at a time like this? The entire world is dying, and if I left, I would likely be consumed by the starlight anyways,” Ray Nora replied, smiling as she shook her head. “I’ve decided to stay. This is the best seat to witness the end of the world—a spectacle too grand to miss.”

Zhou Ming simply nodded, his grip tightening on the steering wheel as he steered the ship toward the distant sunlight in the darkness.

The sunlight fluctuated, dimming and then brightening again. Amidst the intense radiance, Zhou Ming seemed to already perceive the grand corona and the ancient “deity” beneath it.

Occasionally, voices from the distant, disintegrating Boundless Sea, where he had left many “observation nodes,” reached his mind.

“…This is Frost. A curtain of stars is gradually spreading from the direction of the frigid ice field,” Tyrian informed him. “The distant sea surface has vanished, a clear rift has appeared in the clouds… it’s quite spectacular. We are prepared here.”

Then Agatha's (shadow) voice followed: "The cathedral has gathered many survivors. I am with another 'Agatha'; we are looking after the children here… They don't fully grasp what's happening. I've told the children that this is a necessary process to usher in the new 'Dawn', assuring them that everything will soon be alright."

"Morpheus also observed starlight above the western seas. It's rapidly approaching us. There's some unrest in the city, but it's not too bad, it'll be over soon," Sailor's voice sounded casual, "I'm with Captain Lawrence, and we are standing on the city walls with others from the White Oak. We just agreed, when the starlight comes, we'll all close our eyes, count to three, and then open…"

From another location, Morris shared his observations: 'Here in Pland, nothing significant has occurred yet. We can only see the stars at the horizon. I'm with my family, and from here, we can see the trail you left in the sky. It's truly a breathtaking sight,' he said, his voice filled with awe.

In the silence, Zhou Ming attentively listened to these distant voices. Assisted by the 'beacons' scattered across the Boundless Sea, he sensed the ongoing shifts within the shelter. After a considerable pause, he nodded slightly, expressing gratitude, 'Thank you all for holding on.'

However, soon after, the mental link echoed the voices of Tyrian and Agatha, then unexpectedly, their signals vanished. Shortly thereafter, Sailor's and Lawrence's signals also disappeared.

Hours later, the starlight's ascension led to the dissolution of more than half the city-states in the Boundless Sea. The ancient sanctuary, established by kings long past and operational for ten thousand years following the Great Annihilation, rapidly contracted to a third of its original expanse, continuing to diminish swiftly.

In Pland, the last lights of the city-state night lit up, and amidst the clouds and mist, the chaotic roars of unseen entities echoed. Enormous, shadowy figures twisted and swelled between the city's rooftops and towers in a final, desperate frenzy, reaching towards the distant curtain of starlight.

Atop the high walls of the shelter in the upper city area, Vanna and Heidi stood together as the encircling starlight curtain rose around them. Heidi, overwhelmed by the sight, whispered, 'So beautiful…'

Vanna smiled in response, 'Didn't I always tell you? The captain always ensures a spectacle—you never believed me.'

Feeling a bit defeated, Heidi replied, 'My 'Miss Knight,' remember I've always stayed within the city. I haven't experienced as much of the world as you have.'

'Isn't the world within a madman's mind enough?' Vanna retorted playfully.

'Let's not talk about work at the end of the world,' Heidi quickly said, adding, 'I hope psychiatrists in the new world won't need guns to battle delusions.'

The two longtime friends continued their conversation about the impending new world. Nearby, Morris, looking pensive, whispered to his wife, 'Do you think… our daughter and Vanna are a bit…'

'Impossible, right?' his wife responded, reflecting his thoughts.

'I used to think it impossible too, but the captain said it's possible…'

As the curtain of starlight finally reached the sea's edge near Pland, Shirley instinctively clutched Nina's hand, gazing anxiously at the star-filled sky. The roars and strange noises of the city began to fade under the brilliant starlight, the world around them growing ominously quiet."

The voice of Dog emanated from the shadows at Shirley's feet, saying, "Pland lies at the heart of the Boundless Sea… the starlight is now closing in on the city-state's coastline, leaving only this city remaining in this world."

"I used to really dislike this city," Shirley whispered, her voice tinged with a mixture of nostalgia and sadness, "with its perpetually waterlogged and foul-smelling alleys, the chilly, unwelcoming houses, and the incessant noise from the thunderous factories. But now… I find myself hesitant to leave."

Nina remained silent, simply offering a comforting pat on Shirley's hand, then bent down to adjust the collar of her "Uncle Duncan," gently nudging him toward the window.

Although her Uncle Duncan could no longer see the world through his own eyes, Nina knew that he retained a faint, lingering connection to this avatar. Her gestures, she hoped, might provide some solace as he faced the imminent Great Annihilation.

"Uncle Duncan," she said quietly, "the lights at the city's edge have snuffed out. I just witnessed the tallest rooftops in the Crossroad dissolve into the starlight. It seems it will soon be our turn."

Nina raised her eyes to the sky, observing the majestic blaze of firelight sweeping across it, hidden partially by clouds. This fire, now entering the rear of the World's Creation, left only its spectacular tail flame, which cast an entrancing glow that was reflected in her eyes.

Shortly after, she felt a response echo within her heart: "Yes, I'm almost there."

"Is it dark where you are?" she asked tentatively.

“In the areas devoid of sunlight, it’s pitch-black, like the back of the World’s Creation,” the voice replied, “unlike the side facing the Boundless Sea which emits a pale light. But when the sun shines, it becomes incredibly bright – the Black Sun is directly ahead; I’ve already seen it.”

“Take care on your journey,” Nina advised softly, “Shirley and I are waiting for you.”

“Okay.”

The voice in her mind faded away. Nina squinted, watching as the magnificent blaze was slowly concealed by the World’s Creation. Out of the corner of her eye, she noticed another city block quietly merging into the starry sky.

The starlight continued to encroach above Pland, and now, only a few structures stood defiantly against the impending darkness.

Shirley gripped her hand once more, revealing his usual bravado to be a facade for his underlying timidity.

Nina smiled reassuringly, holding Shirley’s hand tighter. She gazed into the pervading starlight, whispering almost to herself, “Just keep moving forward… don’t worry, just keep going…”

She turned to look directly into Shirley’s eyes, which were illuminated by the spreading starlight.

“Shirley, you can blink now.”

As they watched, the starlight finally sealed completely above Pland, swallowing the last tangible section of the Boundless Sea. Every sound, every material, all history—everything that had ever been born, destroyed, great, mediocre, noble, sinful—all was absorbed into the quiet stillness of the starlight, leaving nothing behind.

Thus, the world was obliterated.

Chapter 850: Depth 0, Assignment

After a tumultuous period, peace finally descended.

Silence enveloped everything: the continuous internal chatter within the mind, the feedback from countless environmental sensors, the calming guidance from Nina, and the soothing updates from Vanna and Morris—all ceased abruptly as the stars within this realm merged, annihilating the world's very essence.

This sacred sanctuary, built by ancient rulers and enduring for ten thousand years, quietly dissolved into the cosmic birth of a new universe.

Amidst a chaotic tapestry woven from the remnants of numerous worlds, only one ship, the Vanished, continued its final voyage, navigating the edges of the newly forming universe. Beneath its hull lay a deep fissure that had spanned the Boundless Sea for eons, its other side revealing a starkly different landscape—

Standing at the helm of the Vanished, Zhou Ming fearlessly opened his eyes, now freed from the constraints of the old world. Looking through the burning remains of the deck and the gaps in the hull, he saw a dark, endless fissure absorbing all light, its depth almost causing dizziness. Though the details within the abyss were obscured, it hinted at an immense vastness, feeling like falling into an infinite void.

Above this abyss, the Black Sun shone brightly, its light cutting through the surrounding darkness. The grand celestial body continued to emit strong,

clear navigational signals, although they were no longer necessary for the Vanished.

Beside Zhou Ming stood Alice, no longer atop a barrel but on a small piece of the remaining deck, while Ray Nora stood next to the doll.

“What are you thinking about?” Zhou Ming asked suddenly.

“I’m not thinking about anything!” Alice replied with a cheerful tone, her face briefly showing confusion before she smiled and added, “It’s quite fascinating to see what lies behind the World’s Creation.”

“Aren’t you afraid?” Zhou Ming asked, expecting her usual response.

“Not scared,” Alice indeed shook her head, puzzled about her lack of fear.

Zhou Ming smiled and then turned to Ray Nora: “And you?”

“I was just reflecting on the serenity of the world’s end,” Ray Nora shared, her voice calm and her face tranquil. “Growing up, I was haunted by distorted, violent visions and sounds from the deep sea. I imagined the Great Annihilation as a catastrophic event filled with terror and destruction. Yet, it occurred in complete silence. As everything faded away, there was no sound, not even the roars of the brave or the screams of the fearful. It felt surreal, almost like descending from here might still reveal the endless blue ocean and the sunlight scattering across the water.”

Zhou Ming remained silent, and after a few seconds, Ray Nora sighed softly. “I should leave now,” she announced.

“Leaving now?” Zhou Ming asked, surprised. “There’s nowhere to go at this moment.”

“I know, but it’s time for me to detach the ‘Drifting House’ from this place,” Ray Nora replied, smiling. “Having seen the scenery of the Great Annihilation, I yearn to continue my journey in the new world.”

“I understand,” Zhou Ming responded, nodding slightly. “Then I wish you a safe journey—the Vanished will always keep a door open for your ‘Drifting House,’ even in the new world.”

“Thank you,” Ray Nora smiled warmly, then stepped back. “See you in the new world.”

She then left the helm, descending the fragmented stairs to the still-standing “Door of the Lost.” A beam of light soon flashed brilliantly against the starry backdrop as she departed.

Back at the helm, the deck began to contract and collapse, the remaining structures of the Vanished disintegrating under the glow of the starlit flames. The illusion of the mast and the linked structures disappeared last.

Zhou Ming gazed upwards toward the distant “sunlight,” then looked down, holding the last piece of the helm. After a moment, he released it.

“You’ve worked hard,” he whispered to the ship.

He walked to the edge of the helm, passing through the nearly transparent remains of the stairs and decks. Alice followed closely. They reached the captain’s cabin door at the stern, which was nearly gone.

Even the “Door of the Lost” stood nearly transparent, quiet in its original place. Through this door, Zhou Ming saw the last remaining part of the Vanished—a black wooden goat head floating above the chart table, turning to look at Alice and Zhou Ming.

Zhou Ming approached Goathead, illuminated by starry illusions, while the last structures of the Vanished continued to disintegrate around him.

“That’s about it,” he said to his first officer. “The Vanished should now rest—Atlantis is also waiting for you.”

“Keep a spot for me on the Vanished in the new world,” Goathead requested, its wooden face seemingly smiling as it raised its neck. “Decide what form that will be.”

“Alright,” Zhou Ming nodded.

Goathead exhaled softly, and after a brief silence, it squinted its eyes and revisited their initial and final question.

“Name?”

“Zhou Ming.”

Brilliant starlight burst from the core structure of the Vanished following the answer, engulfing the illusion of Saslokha’s spine and head. In an instant, the entire ship dissolved into nothingness within the starlight, leaving behind only a few lingering points of light drifting slowly.

Alice watched the scene with wide eyes. She raised her hand as if to catch those drifting points of light. When a tiny light touched her fingertip, she suddenly realized something. She smiled, waving her hand vigorously: “Goodbye, Mr. First Mate, goodbye, see you in the new world!”

The faint glimmers of light vanished, and Miss Alice gradually ceased her arm movements. In the enveloping darkness, she paused to contemplate before raising her gaze to Zhou Ming. “Captain, what’s our next move? Is there still some distance to cover? I can see the Black Sun looming ahead; how do we navigate to it?”

Zhou Ming chuckled, affectionately tousled Alice’s hair, and pointed behind the doll.

Taken aback, Alice turned around.

There, suspended in the void, was a magnificently ornate wooden box, familiar and quietly majestic.

“I’ve kept this apart for you; now, the choice is yours,” Zhou Ming stated, standing beside her.

A wave of realization washed over Alice, bringing a joyful smile to her face.

She approached the wooden box and leaned down to caress it tenderly as if reuniting with a cherished companion. She softly ran her fingers across its surface, murmuring, “Hello there… we’re embarking on a new journey!”

Zhou Ming’s laughter filled the air as he stepped into the wooden box, followed by Alice. The box, resembling a modest-sized canoe, was compact yet spacious enough for two to stand inside.

Alice reached for the floating lid of the box but hesitated, her expression uncertain as she glanced at Zhou Ming. “Captain, can we really make it across? There’s no water here…”

With a serene smile, Zhou Ming surveyed the encompassing void and darkness. As they stood within a realm obscured by the World’s Creation, the darkness around them began to ripple.

“Now we can,” he assured her.

Alice blinked, tentatively nudging the wooden box with the lid in the darkness—it moved. Her face lit up with excitement, and she began to energetically wave the lid like an oar, rowing vigorously through the darkness. It was reminiscent of their initial voyage, chasing the elusive Vanished across the vast expanses of the Boundless Sea. The wooden box picked up speed in the darkness, propelling both the doll and her captain toward the distant gleam of sunlight.

As they sailed, time and space seemed to dissolve into irrelevance. The small canoe-like box coursed through a dark crevice toward the distant light. Alice did not know how long she had rowed; she only knew that Zhou

Ming was always by her side, and the distant sun maintained its elusive distance—until suddenly, it was incredibly near. What had appeared as a distant sun transformed into a vast, fiery sea stretching infinitely in every direction below them, its immense flames shooting up like a silent, cold tempest.

Alice ceased her rowing and leaned forward to peer below, then turned to Zhou Ming with a wide, beaming smile. “We’ve arrived!”

Zhou Ming remained silent for a lengthy moment before finally exhaling softly. “Yes, we have arrived.”

Alice did not question his prolonged silence, seeming to grasp the entirety of the moment. Following his acknowledgment, she carefully set the wooden box lid aside and looked up into Zhou Ming’s eyes. Her radiant smile slowly settled into a tranquil expression.

“Captain, see you in the new world.”

“Yeah, see you in the new world.”

“And don’t forget my little flat-bottomed pan~”

“Of course.”

Content with their journey’s conclusion, the doll dissolved into the brilliance of the stars.

Zhou Ming stood silently over the fiery sea of the Black Sun. After an indeterminate time, he turned to look at his shoulder.

In the fading starlight, the silhouette of Ai flickered, appearing and disappearing intermittently.

The dove cocked its head, appearing to observe its master with a curious gaze. When their eyes locked, the bird suddenly flapped its wings energetically and made an odd, piercing noise as if it were experiencing

some kind of glitch. Its voice rang out in a repetitive chant: “To the new world, to the new world, to the new world! Announcing a limited-time event for the new UR! Enhanced probability for the Duncan-Zhou Ming card! SSR card ‘Alice’ reissued for a limited time! To the new world! To the new world!”

Zhou Ming’s brow furrowed in confusion.

Normally, he could grasp the gist of the dove’s cryptic messages, but this message seemed unusually perplexing. What on earth was the dove trying to convey?

Before Zhou Ming could voice his bewilderment, Ai’s silhouette had already begun to fade into the starlight. The dove flapped its wings once more, and its typically dim green bean-like eyes suddenly took on a contemplative look. Then, it turned to face Zhou Ming with a serious expression.

“Goodbye—”

And with that, the dove faded away.

Zhou Ming watched this spectacle in silent amazement for a long while before he resignedly shook his head and muttered to himself, “I thought this dove would stay by my side until the end.”

His words hung unanswered in the air. Even the “sun” burning below his feet offered no reply.

Zhou Ming had realized that the Black Sun was no longer alive when Alice rowed the wooden box close to this fiery sea. The Black Sun had ceased its thoughts quietly during this time; it offered no farewells or final words.

What remained here was merely a corpse that still burned in a consistent pattern, acting like a beacon that continued to light the path even after the Great Annihilation.

This flame was the final “gift” that the Black Sun had left for Zhou Ming.

“You kept your promise, so I shall too.”

With a rueful smile and a shake of his head, Zhou Ming’s figure slowly descended into the sea of fire, eventually feeling as if he stood on solid ground.

The flame, once possessed by the Black Sun but now without an owner, continued to burn beside him as if waiting… “to be taken over.”

Zhou Ming narrowed his eyes as he surveyed the surrounding sea of fire, and a term suddenly came to his mind: Flame Usurper.

Thus began the ultimate usurpation of the fire.

In an instant, the flames left by the Black Sun transformed into a beacon of starlight, this luminous “celestial body” made of entangled information and chaotic beliefs was bathed in starlight, reigniting and exploding into a brilliant flash that illuminated everything in an infinitely brief moment.

That intense “illumination” cast the starlight into the crack of the World’s Creation—this too was an infinitely brief moment.

After this moment, time truly lost all meaning.

The Black Sun, this last relic of the old world, the final fragment left at this moment after the convergence of thousands of worlds, was completely dissolved in the starlight.

The Great Annihilation is completed.

…

All was swallowed by the echoing emptiness of the Great Annihilation; time and space both turned into null values and that nearly eternal yet infinitely brief “instant”… began.

A lone consciousness remained, this entity floated in the void, traversing this eternal moment.

It began to think, and to calculate.

The first parameter of the mathematical machine was set into motion, initiating a sequence that spanned an age so long it felt eternal. Following this, the second parameter was meticulously adjusted—a task that, though it lasted only a moment, seemed to stretch beyond any measurable time.

The machine continued in its purpose, constantly calculating in its deep thought process.

In a span of time that was at once unimaginably vast and yet paradoxically fleeting, the machine commenced its primary task. It began organizing all that had been promised, assigning everything its rightful position within a scale of information that was both computable and beyond true comprehension.

Still engaged in its calculations, the machine pondered endlessly.

It then proceeded to establish the tempo for all operations within this embryonic mathematical universe. The earlier stages were dedicated to its design, while the stages that followed would open up to a future brimming with possibilities.

This phase, too, consumed what felt like an infinite moment.

…

The call was made.

From the old world—the task had been completed.

The focus shifted.

To the new world—a new model was integrated.

Thus, the perpetual first second ticked by.

Zhou Ming-Duncan opened his eyes.

The void of darkness was mirrored in his gaze.

…

He uttered a single word,

“Let there be light.”

Chapter 852: Depth -1, To the New World

Below **MTL**, be careful!

***

Then, there was light.

And that was a long, long time ago—or maybe just a moment ago.

After all, if the Algrade astrologers' theory is correct, the birth of this universe may have happened only recently—although for the time scale of all beings in the universe, it may have been an "event billions of years ago", but for another time scale higher than all things in the universe, the time span of billions of years is just an insignificant parameter.

But who cares? After all, a senior who has to finish his biology thesis all day and sleeps less than six hours a day will definitely not care about such "things in the sky"—the astronomy school next door may care, but that's another matter, their credits are tied to this.

Borno was holding a large stack of materials he had just borrowed from the library, and he ran hurriedly across the large walkway on the top floor of the academy city, as if he could bring up a gust of wind behind him.

He ran past an elf gentleman with messy hair and who looked severely sleep-deprived, and almost bumped into him.

“No running on the upper trail!” The messy-haired elf staggered and loudly reminded the short guy who came out of nowhere—judging from his body size and the distinctive, cat-like ears, he should be a student of the Gypro tribe, a race that is always so reckless.

“I’m sorry, sir!” Borno stopped in a hurry, turned around, and bent down to apologize in a posture that seemed like he was about to throw the pile of books in his arms at the gentleman opposite him. “I was in a hurry to see my tutor. I stayed in the library for too long. I looked up at the watch and found that I was almost half an hour late! I’m very sorry. Did I hurt you?”

The sincerity and nervousness of the young man Jipro worked, and Mr. Elf waved his hand helplessly: “Okay, go ahead. It’s no small matter to stand up your mentor - but don’t rush around like this. The world won’t be destroyed just because you run a little slower.”

“Yes… Thank you sir! Goodbye sir! I’m leaving sir!”

Borno bowed repeatedly, and hurriedly caught the book that was about to slip out of his arms. Then he turned around and walked quickly to the other end of the trail.

The elf man with messy hair and dark circles under his eyes due to lack of sleep looked at the young man who ran away recklessly and shook his head helplessly.

He heard footsteps coming from the side. He looked up in the direction of the sound and saw a familiar figure approaching nearby. He smiled and raised his hand to greet the other person: “Ted, it’s rare to see you have time to take a walk at this time.”

“It’s even rarer to see you willing to come out of your lab and breathe the air outside,” Ted Lill glanced at the elf scholar in front of him and said jokingly, “Didn’t you say that elves only need to take in basic vitamins and

maintain fifteen minutes of sunlight and two minutes of outdoor activities every day to maintain their vital signs?”

“I thought so—but my doctor didn’t,” Taran Eyre shrugged. “He kicked me out of the lab.”

“…Good job,” Ted Lear rolled his eyes. “If no one is watching over your body, you will die young before 2,000 years old. Honestly, the world is so good, don’t you want to live a few more years, take a good look at it before you die? Why are you so rude?”

Listening to the unceremonious teasing and teachings from his long-time friend, Taran El just smiled awkwardly and touched his nose without any rebuttal.

“Yeah… that’s good…”

He muttered softly, then slowly raised his head and looked towards the end of the promenade, his eyes passing over the spire of the academy’s tower, over the high walls, over the vast plains and hills outside the city, looking towards the horizon.

There is magnificent green like mountains rolling on the land, huge tree shadows standing at the end of the horizon, and the light green phantom light emanating from the top of the treetops diffuses in the sky like the aurora, and turns into rivers of light flowing to the plains. The green is like veins, winding across the land, some flowing on the surface, some seeping into the ground, and disappearing at the end of certain tributaries.

Those energy flows called “Loka’s Touch” penetrate deep underground and interweave into a larger network near the mantle, wrapping the entire planet between the crust and the mantle—and wherever the energy flows, it is blessed by Silantis.

This “Academy City” was built on the largest energy focus on the Breeze Plain.

But in fact, these “energy focuses” are of no use to the operation of the city itself—the city needs electricity and fuel to operate, and the only function of the energy focus deep underground is to enable the elves to establish more direct communication with Silantis.

Silantis likes to chat with people—and so does Sasloka, who is online during breaks in his patrols.

Taran El squinted his eyes, the bright sunlight shining on his face, bringing a warm heat that made people unable to help but feel sleepy.

“Have you heard about that?” Ted Riel’s voice came from the side, waking Taran El from his drowsiness, “The astrologers of Algrad—they learned something incredible.” ʀÅNöβÈṢ

“…There is always all kinds of information flowing in the border area, and there is long-term and stable communication between Terra and the border area. What’s more…the Algrad people are a race that is very sensitive to the stars,” Taran El said slowly, “I don’t think this is a big problem—if the world is like this, then it should be like this. Since they have noticed it, let them know. After all…there are so many equally sensitive and intelligent races living in the depths of such a vast starry sky, and what we can touch and influence is always only the smallest part of it…”

As the great scholar spoke, he slowly stretched out in the sunshine, took a deep breath as if he wanted to absorb the sunshine into his lungs, and then slowly exhaled.

“Ted, don’t think too much. Just enjoy the air and breeze, as well as the warm sunshine, like me… To be honest, I’m really starting to like being outdoors. It turns out that basking in the sun is such a good thing.”

Ted Riel glanced at Taran, and then seemed to suddenly relax. He smiled and shook his head, then squinted his eyes like Taran, letting the warm sunlight shine on his face.

But after a while, he seemed to suddenly remember something and couldn't help muttering, "Speaking of which, what do you think of 'him'? There are original intelligent creatures in the stars who have begun to spontaneously perceive certain mysteries in the process of the birth of this world…"

Taran Eyre shrugged. "Him? He doesn't have any opinion."

"……how do you know?"

"Lady Lucrecia told me last time when she came back that he has a lot of things to do right now, and as for the various situations that arise during the development of the native intelligent creatures among the stars… he only adheres to one principle: as long as they don't overturn the house, he doesn't care."

"… Are you being too lenient?"

"Who knows?" Taran El said casually, "There's a saying… Oh, do your best to ensure the 'possibility' that this world has, that's probably what it means."

Ted Lear thought about it and felt that there was a very profound and convincing truth in this, so he decided not to dwell on this topic. He just asked with a little curiosity: "Do you know what 'he' is busy with now?"

"Then I have no idea. Anyway…it's such a big place, he must have a lot of things to do."

Taran El said, looking up at the distant sky.

He seemed to be gazing at an endlessly distant place—beyond the planets, beyond the galaxies, in the ripples of space and time, deep in some endless

space-time structure that was beyond the comprehension of human intelligence.

He had revisited the place only briefly in a few guided visions.

Visited the ship.

That place where the “old holy spirits” gather in the oldest and most obscure legends of the Patmosans -

……

“This is the situation,” the tall Vanna stood up. In some stories deep in the starry sky, she was also called the “Saintess with the Sword,” or “The One Who Shoots Down the Stars,” or “The Lady of Falling Stars.” She said seriously, “It’s a little tricky. Maybe we have to go there in person.”

The tall and majestic figure at the end of the long table remained silent, while Shirley, who was sitting opposite the table, had already slumped down with her head in her hands. She had been called “the lady who patrols the sky” or “the star thrower” by the Bamosas since some time ago. “But I just had a day off yesterday!”

“We have to save them at least,” Agatha (Shadow), the “Gemini Stars” and “The Protector in the Mirror” who was sitting at a corner of the long table, shook her head, “At least they are on the ship…”

“Just don’t let this get out,” Morris said with a delicate expression, smoking his pipe and glancing at the tall figure at the end of the long table—he had so many titles that sometimes even he couldn’t remember them all. “The main thing is to make sure it doesn’t get to the Leviathans. They’ve protested three times…”

The tall figure at the end of the long table finally moved, and the discussions on both sides of the table finally quieted down a little.

All eyes fell on the captain with expectation.

The figure stood up from the darkness—Duncan Zhou Ming looked around at the followers gathered here, and after a long period of silence with a complicated expression, he finally sighed, his expression gradually going crazy:

“So, who can first explain what ‘while traveling, Lenoira tricked the Leviathan Queen who ran away from home to go and admire the cosmic explosion, but they were both stuck in a space crack due to gravitational collapse and had to send a distress signal to find someone to help get them out’ means—and then briefly explain why it was the fourth time?! What about the first three times?!”

Nina, who was standing by, immediately raised her head and looked around carefully, muttering, “Shouldn’t you explain what the Big Bang is first? It sounds very interesting…”

As soon as Nina finished speaking, the goat head on the table immediately raised its neck and said excitedly, “Hey, I know this. I went to see it during the last patrol mission. It was when the quasar encountered…”

As soon as it started to speak, everyone around the table said in unison: “Shut up!”

“……Oh.”

***

(Season finale!)

(Yes, the depth 0 in the previous chapter is indeed the finale of the Deep Sea, but even if the era of the Deep Sea Ends, their story continues, so -

Depth -1

The Lost Homeland is still sailing.)

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